

P I R A T E A B A

the WANDERING INN



BOOK 4

WINTER
SOLSTICE

Winter Solstice

The Wandering Inn, Book 4

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When he was young, he had always dreamed of walking among other races. But now all he dreamed about was death and fire. The Goblin King burned city after city to the ground, damning the screaming inhabitants by death and fire. Across the ocean, his Goblin Lords led similar crusades, pillaging, slaughtering.

There was only war. The peace he had sought for so long was a false lie. That was what the King realized. His armies burned across the continent, fighting Drakes, Undead, Antinium, Gnolls and Humans alike. They could not be stopped. There was only death in his heart, and the fury to destroy the world. With it he slew the greatest of heroes they sent against him.

Rage. All consuming. It burned him and he howled it as his warriors fought and died and leveled. He would kill them all.

And then Rags woke. She started, still tasting smoke and blood, still full of the Goblin King's fury. She slipped and nearly fell—the Carn Wolf she sat on shifted and Rags clung to its fur, eliciting a mild noise of complaint. But it had been trained too well to protest.

In a moment, Rags was sitting upright. She blinked around and realized that they'd stopped. After nearly two weeks of nonstop marching, they had arrived.

Where, exactly?

The young Goblin sat up on her mount, letting it—him—pace restlessly ahead. She was riding in the center of the army.

Her army, supposedly. Rags frowned as she looked around. As ever, a group of Hobs walked with her, as did several of Garen's elite wolf riders. And past them?

A sea of Goblin heads flowed past Rags, and the noise of their passing washed over her. Goblins were by and large fairly quiet as a people; they preferred gestures to words and they had learned to be quiet long ago, lest they attract attention.

But thousands of marching Goblins, armored warriors who rattled with every step, noncombatants who carried packs, horses and mules and donkeys, animals liberated from Human farms, and Goblin infants, uncharacteristically quiet for babies but still occasionally noisy—all produced a din of their own.

It was an army worthy of any Chieftain. More than worthy, in fact. Rags knew her own forces, that was to say the former tribes she had personally subjugated and now controlled, were mixed into the lot. But she only commanded the huge mass. The assembled Goblins were not *hers*, and that was an important distinction.

Still, they didn't fight or quarrel, and that was important. Disunity could be death here, in the heart of Human lands.

Not that there were any around. Rags looked and saw only trees. They'd been marching through a forest full of annoying trees with burrs the size of walnuts that clung to clothing and pierced skin with their sharp needles. Tall stone loomed ahead of her, and snow mixed with rotting leaves lay underfoot. Only the trees, brown and lifeless, made any impression on the landscape.

They were close to the mountain. Rags stared up at it grimly, knowing they had to be close. This was their destination, after all.

Long ago the flat grasslands had given way to forests and hills, and then to an area of rocky land where a lone mountain sat high above everything else.

It wasn't much of a mountain to Rags, who'd grown up in the shadows of the High Passes, staring up at peaks so tall that no one had ever climbed them. But the mountain was their destination, and it seemed that after staring up at it for days, they'd finally reached the base of it.

Rags sat astride the large Carn Wolf and stared up at the massive cliff face that met the edge of the forest. She had no idea why they were here, so far from home. Well, she had some idea, but Garen Redfang had been reluctant to tell anyone his full plan when he'd told them where to go when they marched north.

Perhaps she should have argued harder. But Rags had known at the time that he was right. It was just that she couldn't stand the long days of not knowing what was going on! The assembled tribes needed an ally in their war against the Goblin Lord, that she knew. But would they find it here,

near Invrisil, where adventurers roamed in great numbers and slew any monster they found?

Rags hoped so. Or else they would all die here. She shivered in the cold and drew the fur coat more tightly around her. She remembered. This was not a memory of times long past; it was her memory, fresh and vivid.

The Goblin army was a black mass that swarmed up the walls of the Human city, climbing ladders, fighting with the Human defenders among the broken gates.

Black armor. That was what set these Goblins apart from ordinary rabble. Also, no tribe would have dared to attack a Human city. But these Goblins did not fear the burning fire and lightning that the enchantments on the walls spat down at them. Their arrows flew upwards, catching the mages who tried to burn the dark shafts out of the air.

Humans fell and died. It was simply that there were not enough of them to man the walls and stem the black tide that attacked from every direction. This was a Goblin army, superior in numbers to any other force.

The knot of desperate men and women slowly grew smaller around the north gate. Soon the Goblins would gain a foothold there, and then they would be in the city, too late to stop.

Now was the time. Rags raised her hand.

Now.

The first wave of Goblins hit the black-armored Goblins at the same time as the rain of arrows and crossbow bolts fell from the sky. Elite Goblins mounted on Carn Wolves tore into the unguarded backs of the Goblin Lord's forces, causing havoc while Hobs strode next to their smaller kin, besieging the bewildered Goblin force from behind.

From where she sat Rags smiled grimly. The Goblin Lord's forces hadn't expected to be attacked, much less by their own kind.

Crush them against the walls.

Rags ordered more forces into the fight, reinforcing places where her forces were weak. But there wasn't much for her to do; she'd already positioned countless archers and her Goblins armed with crossbows where they could rain death down upon the Goblins.

They were outnumbered in truth. But Rags' forces were aided by the Humans fighting on the walls and the fact that they'd cornered the Goblin Lord here. And one more thing ensured their victory.

"Redfang! Redfang!"

A streak of crimson. A Goblin warrior sitting astride a huge wolf. Garen Redfang's warriors howled as they plunged into the ranks of the enemy, following their leader. Rags watched Garen carving his way through the enemy, feeling both jealous and relieved at the same time.

They were on the same side, and she knew he belonged at the front. But she wished she could be fighting too, rather than stuck overseeing the battle.

And yet, this was it. Rags watched, viciously pleased as the Goblins in black armor began to rout. They'd done it. They'd won!

But where was the Goblin Lord? Rags hadn't seen anyone remotely like a leader in the army—at least, not like the image in her head. She'd expected a warrior like Garen, or a spellcaster full of magical power. But she hadn't seen anyone like that. Perhaps the Goblin Lord was like her?

Below her, Goblins fled. Goblins died. But Rags could feel little pity for these invaders who wore another tribe's colors. She had seen what they left in their wake. These Goblins slaughtered villages, put crops to the torch. They were destroyers, not scavengers. They didn't fight to survive, they fought to kill and pillage.

And rape. She had seen that too. So Rags cut down the stragglers and wiped this army from the face of the map. And as she stood with her small band of guards witnessing the last of the violence, she felt uncertain. Because the battle was won, but she didn't know if the Goblin Lord had survived the battle.

Her answer came when Garen rode towards her, covered in blood, still wild-eyed from the adrenaline pumping in his veins. Rags strode towards him. She was nearly hopping with impatience.

Goblin Lord. Where?

She wanted Garen to say he'd killed the Lord. But Garen just stared at her strangely.

"This was not the Goblin Lord's army. This was just one of his warbands."

And then the ground fell out from beneath Rags. She stared at the devastation, at the Human city broken by this army. But it was not a true victory for this was only a fraction of her enemy's strength. She had underestimated the power of a Lord and so for the first time—

She felt fear.

A warband. Rags shivered at the thought. Or maybe it was just because she was cold. She sneezed and wiped her hand on the Carn Wolf's fur. That was the convenient thing about riding the wolf, for all they were hard on the butt and bounced Rags about. Their fur was nice and easy to wipe hands and feet clean on, although the wolves tended to bite if they noticed you doing it.

Perhaps a Human – like Erin – would have just shrugged and said 'so what?' upon hearing that this was a Goblin warband. But Goblins understood how their kind made war. There was a simple, almost instinctual way they organized, and so from this Rags understood the dangers of the Goblin Lord's main force.

No one had ever taught Rags about percentages, so she thought of it like this. Goblin armies were always a huge mass, but they always fragmented their forces in order to attack most efficiently. Around two thirds would constitute the main force which moved slowly from place to place, devouring and razing everything in its path. But the remaining third would break down into warbands and raiding parties that spread out in the path of the main army, seizing supplies, recruiting other Goblin tribes, and clashing with smaller forces.

A warband constituted around a tenth of the actual army's force, so that it could be easily replaced if lost. The same went for raiding parties, which were less than a hundredth of the size of the actual army. But what that meant was that if this warband Rags' forces had crushed numbered in the thousands, the Goblin Lord's army numbered in the tens of thousands.

All together, the combined tribes of the High Passes numbered little less than two thousand warriors. Rags had known in an instant what would happen if they were to lead their forces against such a huge enemy. Any Goblin could figure that out, really.

Except maybe Garen Redfang. He thought they could skirmish with the Goblin Lord's forces, but that was because he was used to a small tribe with groups of elite mounted warriors. If all the Goblins tried that they would be very dead, very quickly.

So Rags had ordered their forces north, against Garen's objections, to buy time. It had taken some doing but she'd pointed out the obvious to the surly Goblin Chieftain. If the combined tribes around the High Passes were equivalent to one of the Goblin Lord's warbands, they had no hope of facing his main force.

So, north. Surprisingly, once Garen had accepted the idea he had been the one to lead them to this spot. He claimed to know where another Goblin tribe was based, one strong enough to help fight the Goblin Lord.

It had been a long journey, although not necessarily a difficult one. Rags had been more concerned with affairs inside the tribe rather than any external threat. The most exciting thing that had happened had been when they'd spotted the magical carriage. But it had gotten away.

And the trip had been helpful for Rags in another way. She'd gotten to know her tribe better—that was to say, she now knew who was loyal to her and who was not. And she'd gotten stronger.

Rags had leveled many times over the journey. Not so much as a [Mage] or [Tinkerer], and certainly not as her old class – [Scavenger]. But through Garen's intense training she'd leveled up as a [Warrior], gained two levels as a [Tactician], and more than ten as a [Leader]. Soon, the other Chieftains told her, her [Leader] class would turn into a [Chieftain] class, unique to their race.

That was the good bit. But Rags knew the bad bit started and ended with one simple fact: somehow, in some way, she'd suddenly lost her position as leader over all the tribes. Not that she'd ruled over all the tribes to begin with—this was a coalition army. But...

She was *not* in command here. In battles, yes. The few times the Goblins had had to defend themselves all the other Chieftains had obeyed her orders quickly and without complaint, as had their warriors. But they

were not here, joining together because of Rags. And it was not her authority they respected.

It was his.

Garen Redfang appeared out of the trees, riding his huge rust-red Carn Wolf mount. Rags pulled at her wolf's head gently, forcing it to slow down. She stared up at Garen, and not for the first time, resented his physique.

He looked like what all Goblins dreamed of being. Garen was strong. His muscles stood out on his bare chest and he looked like he barely noticed the cold. He was covered in scars, he had a magical sword at his side and a mighty beast under his command—he looked like a proper Chieftain, not Rags.

That was the problem.

Garen Redfang and his tribe were under Rags' command. She had beaten his tribe, and so it was part of hers now. That was how it went, but somehow Garen had made a mess of that simple fact.

He had lost, but somehow, he *hadn't* lost. Rags knew he'd thrown the fight, but a defeat was a defeat in Goblin society. She should have taken his tribe and obtained his unquestioning loyalty unless he challenged her.

But he didn't obey. Garen glanced down at Rags and smiled. But not just in greeting—there was something *patronizing* about his smile, and indeed his attitude. It was as if he was obeying Rags because it was convenient, not because she was Chieftain.

Frankly, it made Rags furious. She jumped off her mount to give her stiff legs a chance to move. She glared up at Garen, ignoring the way his wolf sniffed at her. If it licked her, she'd punch it in the nose.

Report.

He blinked at her, almost as if he was surprised by her tone. But he answered her casually.

“We are here. This is the place where the other tribe lives.”

Here?

Rags glanced around the miserable little forest. This was hardly the place she'd have chosen for a tribe. But Garen just nodded.

“Here. In the Human lands.”

They are strong?

Rags wanted to know all the details he'd withheld from her. But her question seemed to amuse Garen. He laughed loudly, and she flushed. Other Goblins would watch them talk! Garen hadn't dismounted. Did he not understand how to behave in front of his own Chieftain?

Garen pointed at the mountain.

"There. There is where they live. And they are strong, yes."

He raised his voice. Rags saw Goblins' heads turn as he spoke loudly. Garen gestured to the sky.

"This is the land where Goblins are strongest. The Humans have built grand cities and their adventurers fight with all monsters. But the Goblins remain, and fight. This is the place where Goblins are *mighty*."

Rags had never heard of the tribes living to the north. But she had never ventured out of the area around Liscor, never known more than her miserable existence in her small tribe before this. She looked at Garen.

Strongest Goblins live here?

He shrugged, as if he actually wasn't sure.

"On this continent. Aside from Goblin Lord. Others live across the sea. On islands. They are strong too. But here? Yes."

Across the sea?

There were other Goblins on other continents? Rags couldn't imagine it. But Garen nodded. He had seen the world Rags couldn't imagine.

"Some live on Terandria, but fewer. Some on Chandrar too; strong tribes, that live in their own places. Few on Baleros. Fewer still on Rhir. Too much death there. Overwhelming death."

One of the worst kinds of death. Rags shuddered. Garen nodded darkly, baring his teeth in a scowl.

"We live in other places. But the enemies find us wherever we go. The last Goblin King came across sea. Many did. They fought greater enemies than Drakes and Gnolls and Humans."

But tribe here. It is—

Rags hesitated. Inwardly, she cursed the fact that she still couldn't speak the common language like Garen could. The Goblin tongue was so...so... *hard* to use! There were countless words for death, but few words for what she needed.

It is strong? Leader is strong? Will help?

“He is. And he may help. We will see.”

How?

Garen shrugged. Rags wanted to punch him, but he sat too high up. He looked towards the mountain and nodded to Rags.

“I will go. To prepare. You follow.”

That wasn't what was supposed to happen. Rags was supposed to order him to do that, not the other way around! She opened her mouth to shout that at Garen, but he was already wheeling his wolf, letting it lope towards the foot of the mountain.

Disgusted, Rags watched him ride away, already calling out to other Chieftains and his warriors. Not good. She was losing more control over him each day, she felt. What would happen if she lost what control she had left? She didn't know, but she feared the result, especially as she prepared herself to meet this new Chieftain.

Goblin politics. As Headscratcher and the band of Redfang warriors had observed, the situation between Rags and Garen Redfang was anything but ordinary. The Flooded Waters tribe, Rags' tribe, was the largest tribe in the coalition of fifteen or so tribes by a good margin. And the strongest, Rags felt.

They had nearly eight hundred warriors and several thousand Goblins in total, and over *ten* Hobs, the most out of any tribe by far. And yet, Rags didn't count the Redfang tribe when she thought of her tribe. They were with the Flooded Waters tribe, but like Garen, they were separate.

He still gave orders to his tribe, although it was Rags who made sure the warriors were fed. She'd taken over, organized them efficiently and taken the burden off of Garen's beleaguered Hobs, who'd had to do all the work because their Chieftain was a terrible leader when it came to such matters. And yet, if it came down to it, Rags was fairly certain they'd listen to Garen and not her if they butted heads.

Not good. Garen had lost, but he didn't seem to regard losing as being less superior in any way. Normally, Rags would have killed or exiled him for disobeying her orders, but she couldn't because Garen was too strong. If she challenged him, he would beat her easily. Ordinarily Rags would have just sneered and had several Hobs beat him up—a Chieftain ruled by more than just force!—but Garen was quite capable of taking down any number of Hobs she sent at him.

And if she used her Goblins, his tribe would defend him. And if Rags made it a battle between tribes, it wouldn't end until one side was dead and the other crippled. And if that happened, the other Chieftains in this tenuous alliance of tribes would choose sides and either way, it would end in disaster.

This Rags knew, but she didn't *like* it. She could only grit her teeth and bear the humiliation and slights Garen offered her seemingly without thought. He was too strong.

She didn't have to order anyone to follow Garen. He rode off with his warriors and the other Goblins followed. Grumpily, Rags left her wolf—another Goblin would ride it if they could get on without it biting them—and strode off.

She needed to know things. What things? *Anything*. Garen had told her nothing. But who could she ask? Telling other Chieftains she couldn't command Garen was as good as shooting herself with her black crossbow, Rags knew. She had to ask someone from her tribe. But who?

Rags had conquered four tribes with her small one. She had made all of them hers, and she knew most of them thought of her as a proper Chieftain. At least two tribes did. One was...well, she'd absorbed them only a few days before meeting the Redfang tribe, and so she hadn't gained as complete control over them as the others. They respected Garen's strength more than her cunning.

But it was the Chieftains Rags thought about, the former Chieftains, that was. They were hers, too. Chieftains were smart, some of them, and some

knew a lot. So could she ask one of them?

Rags thought. The first tribe she'd attacked was...the Rockjaw tribe. She'd killed their leader herself. Oops.

Well, he was out. What about the second tribe? The Still Grass tribe's leader was alive, but he was young like her. And like Rags, he had risen to power early and his tribe was weak, only having had one Hob when she'd crushed it. She doubted he knew anything of the world.

The third tribe was the least loyal to her, the Fire Bite tribe. Their Chieftain, a Hob, was hard to control. Rags couldn't talk to him.

She ground her sharp teeth together. But wait! There was one last tribe.

The Gold Stone Tribe. Rags hesitated. She'd conquered them literally seconds before the Redfang Tribe had attacked, but to their credit, their Chieftain had instantly thrown all of his support behind Rags like a proper Goblin, when backstabbing her would have led to her instant demise.

Could she trust him? Rags closed her eyes and remembered.

Rags didn't even see him swing his sword. She only saw the Hob next to her move, and then the Gold Stone Chieftain was in front of her, taking the one-handed slash meant for Rags.

Yes, she could trust him. Rags opened her eyes and blinked rapidly. For a second she was still in the past, heart beating rapidly as she stared up at Garen Redfang, sure this was the end. Then she was back in the present, standing on muddy ground as Goblins walked past her.

It was getting easier to do that. Rags had found recalling past events was simpler now that her tribe had grown. She still couldn't 'look' back that far in time, but what she could see was easier, and she could will the visions to happen most of the time.

And it helped in matters like these. Rags began walking through the snow. She didn't have to search to find the Gold Stone Tribe's former Chieftain. He was part of her tribe and assigned to managing them on the march, being the most competent Hob at the job.

She found the Gold Stone Chieftain munching on something as he rested near a tree. He was waiting for the Goblins around him to keep moving forwards—Rags had passed by a pile of Goblins. One idiot had slipped and the others had all fallen down because of that.

Rags eyed the former Chieftain as he chewed contentedly, scratching at his belly. He was a classical Hob, fat, trusting in his extra body mass to shield him as much as his armor. But like all Hobs he was strong and Rags knew he was fairly good with an axe and shield.

She was about to yell at him for eating—it wasn't meal time! Hobs had to respect her rules and stay away from the rations, the same as everyone else. But then she saw what he was eating.

Pine needles. The Hob was chewing them down slowly, letting the sharp tufts stick out of his mouth. He had a handful of the green needles and, as Rags watched, he shoved some more into his mouth.

She had to admire that. The pine needles were easy to get on the march, and it was a good snack. If you could handle the pricking, that was. She saw several other Goblins around the Chieftain trying to imitate him and spitting out the sharp pine needles after a few moments. But the Gold Stone Chieftain just chewed determinedly, grinding the tough fibers into mush.

He turned as Rags marched over. The Gold Stone Chieftain nodded his head towards her—Rags felt better about that. It wasn't as if Goblins had to salute her or bow, but they did acknowledge their Chieftain.

You. Question.

That was all she said. As far as she knew, the Gold Stone Chieftain had no name. His tribe had no [Shaman] – they were rare – and so he lacked a name. She just thought of him as the Gold Stone Chieftain, which might be how he thought of himself.

Chieftain.

His voice was a rumble. The Gold Stone Chieftain said that word and nothing else. He just chewed his food, waiting for her to say something.

Rags pursed her lips, trying to figure out how to ask her question concisely. She could speak in the Human, or rather, common tongue, but it hurt her throat to try. She pointed at the mountain.

This place. Tribe. Is strong?

It was a question with a lot of nuance, which Garen should have understood when Rags asked him. The Gold Stone Chieftain heard Rags' question and the layers beneath it. Properly translated, her stance, the context in which she was asking and the current state of the tribes meant she was really asking: 'How dangerous is this tribe? Are they likely to betray us? Why has Garen taken us here, and what can I expect?'

At last, the Gold Stone Chieftain nodded. Rags waited with bated breath for his response.

Is strong Goblin. Goblins here is strong.

That was the problem with other Goblins, even other Chieftains. None of them were particularly verbose, which made sense given their language. All he was telling her was that the Chieftain was as strong as his tribe, which was apparently very. She eyed him dourly, and the Hob shrugged as if apologizing.

Talking wasn't his strong suit. Rags turned to go, deciding she'd have to figure out what to do herself. But she heard a grunt, and then a rumble, and words in a language that was not Goblin.

"Chieftain. You. Chieftain?"

She turned, eyes widening. The Gold Stone Chieftain stared at her pensively. For a second, white-hot fury flared up in Rags' chest and she debated taking the shortsword from her belt and stabbing him with it.

But she didn't. It was a question, not an attack. Rags was so angry she didn't reply in Goblin, but again in the common language.

"I...Chieftain. I always...Chieftain!"

She glared at him. The Gold Stone Chieftain met her eyes—not afraid, just searchingly. Then he bowed his head and nodded slowly.

Is so. Will not ask again.

She stared at him, but the Hob just went back to chewing his pine needles. Rags looked around. Other Goblins immediately bowed their heads and pretended to be busy kicking snow, picking nostrils, or throwing prickly burrs at each other. But they had heard.

Was the Gold Stone Chieftain questioning her too? No—as Rags left and calmed down she considered what had been said. He'd questioned her,

yes, but when she'd declared herself as Chieftain he'd acknowledged her in front of the others.

Maybe, just maybe, she had one supporter she could count on. The other Hobs were loyal to her as well, but she had known they could turn on her if dissatisfied, as one of them had when they were losing to the Redfang Tribe. But the Gold Stone Chieftain...could she count on him?

Rags didn't know. But then she found herself striding up to the mountain, and saw where Goblins were streaming into fissures in the stone, caves leading into the mountain. She walked upwards and found herself in another world, in the heart of a small kingdom of Goblins. And there she met the one who called himself Great Chieftain, the Chieftain above all others.

Her cold feet left snowy tracks that melted on the rough stone floor of the city within a mountain. Rags saw other Goblins stumbling on the rough ground; though places had been worn smooth, this was no place of architecture and masonry. The vast tunnel they walked down had been hewn out of the very rock one chip at a time.

By degrees, the darkness of the caverns lightened, as bits of fire appeared overhead, lighting the way. Lanterns hung from rough hemp rope or were strapped to lengths of wood dangled off of balconies, sputtering with the cheap animal fat oil.

The smoke of such flames drifted upwards, to the walkways made out of stone and the bridges of rope and timber where dark shapes scurried about. Upwards, and ever upwards the Goblins looked, for the crisscrossing tunnels and passages led up into the heart of the mountain.

At first, they saw the guards, hidden in alcoves or behind barricades disguised as piled stone. Arrows glinted, but the Goblins watched them carefully without putting any to their bows. They wore steel armor which made even some Hobs look on in jealousy.

Next, they saw other Goblins dragging in a dead bear's carcass, and next to it, the cub, both riddled with arrows. A rat darted out of the shadows to lick at the trail of blood. Another Goblin grabbed the rat, and a few of the roaches which clung to a wall. All things lived here, and all things were eaten.

Upwards, then, traversing stone steps and an open bridge where bat droppings had made footing treacherous. Goblins carrying wood – both firewood and quality pieces cut for the purposes of crafting passed them by, heads bowed, moving fast. There was a rhythm to this place, and a structure.

Then they passed by the huge furnaces which expelled black smoke upwards and felt warmer. The Goblins and Rags saw how the embers in this place never died, being fed coal and wood almost constantly to warm the cavern. And from the fire all things came. Meat was cooked and food made with embers taken from that massive blaze, and metal hammered or the crudest of reforgings done by Goblin [Blacksmiths], whom Rags had never seen before.

And then they reached the heart of the city, and Rags gazed in wonder at the buildings. For after centuries of neglect and habitation by Goblins, the former city of stone still showed traces of what it had been.

Perhaps it was Dwarves who carved into this place, building grand monuments and smoothing the stone. But it was Goblins who broke down windows and walls and strung bridges and rope everywhere that they might travel more easily. As Rags watched, a Goblin climbed higher, headed towards a ledge higher up that led into another passage. The Goblin's grip slipped as he or she reached for the next part of the rope. They tried to stabilize themselves, failed.

The small body fell, and was soon dragged away.

"This is the hall of the Great Chieftain of the North."

That was all Garen Redfang said as Rags walked with him. She stood with him and all the Chieftains of the allied tribes at the head of their army. Most of the other Goblins had stayed behind—going somewhere else—but hundreds still followed the Chieftains, warriors and other Hobs, going to the heart of this place.

Where else could it be but the throne room? Here Rags saw the places meant for statues, smashed and turned instead into more places for Goblins to move about freely. But there was still a majesty to the double doors that stood wide, and as she entered the huge hall, she saw the Chieftain of this place.

It was just a glimpse. Rags saw him past the tables and detritus of the room, sitting on a throne of cloth and dirty pillows. A fat, huge Goblin twice as large as any Hob. But her eye was drawn to the long tables, the

seats made out of stone that had been dragged up here. This was no throne room after all, but a banquet hall.

And there were Goblins in it, enough for a feast. But Rags didn't think there was going to be any party, unless it was the bloody kind.

These Goblins were ready for war. They stood next to the dais and the huge Goblin Chieftain, armed warriors, equal in number or perhaps a little more than the Goblins that had entered with Rags and Garen at their head.

Rags immediately noticed the quality of these Goblin's arms. Steel, again, or iron. Some wore complete sets of plate armor, scavenged from some adventurer's corpse. Others held swords which glowed—they had magical weapons!

And Hobs. There were a lot of them. Rags blinked as she saw tall Goblins, standing next to their smaller bretheren. So many! She counted over thirty before she stopped, and there were far more in the room. Far more.

By that standard alone these Goblins were superior to the trespassers. And it clearly was a message: we are better than you. We are stronger. For all that, Rags felt that Garen's Redfang warriors were no less powerful than the best of the warriors who stood assembled here. And of course none of the Goblins could match the legendary Garen Redfang, not the mightiest Hob warrior among them.

Except perhaps their leader. Rags fixed on him as she walked slowly forwards with Garen. The massive Goblin had not bothered to stand; she wondered if he could, fat as he was. But his huge head was intent as he stared at her. Rags shuddered as she saw his crimson eyes looking towards her, and she sensed his authority. But then the Chieftain's eyes fixed on Garen.

Garen stopped two thirds of the way into the room, and the Goblins stopped behind him. Rags walked past Garen, which made him frown in annoyance. She ignored that; she was the Chieftain, after all.

The huge Chieftain's eyes flicked to Rags for a second, and his lips moved upwards in amusement. But he looked back at Garen. While Rags was wondering what to say, his huge mouth opened and he spoke.

"Garen Redfang. It has been long since you trespassed in my lands."

Rags jumped in surprise. He was speaking in the common language! And fluently! Even Garen didn't speak like that!

And he had addressed Garen. Rags glared. She had to reply back, teach this arrogant Chieftain who the real leader was.

But then Garen spoke. As if he didn't realize what he was doing, he smiled and replied back, claiming Rags' authority in front of the other Goblins.

"It has been long. But I am here for war."

At that the other Goblins standing next to the Chieftain stirred. Rags froze, and she put her hand on the crossbow which she always kept slung to her back. A second and she could have it out and firing. But the Chieftain sitting on his throne only laughed.

"War? Against us? If you wanted that, you would have brought three times the numbers with you, and no children and females."

To Rags' outrage the big Goblin pointed at *her* as he said that. She heard a murmur from the Goblins behind her, but dared not turn to see if it was in support or agreement with the Chieftain. Garen only smiled.

"I have brought many tribes. Strong ones. Smart ones. The one standing here is known as Rags. She is unique."

He had named her, as if she was lesser! Rags nearly exploded, but the Chieftain laughed hugely. He peered at Rags, rising a bit from his bed of softness. She didn't flinch as she met his eyes.

"Hah. Yes. She is small and young, a child still. Do you bed her, Garen Redfang? Or is it because she is your child that you give her power?"

That was it. Rags felt something snap. As she heard the Goblins standing around the Chieftain on the dais laughing, she raised her hand to her back.

The black crossbow was heavy, but Rags could lift it with one hand for a few moments. She pulled it out, cocked the crossbow with one pull that took all her strength, and had a heavy quarrel on the string before the laughter had stopped.

Rags swung the black crossbow up and pointed the bolt straight at the fat Goblin's massive stomach. The entire room went still.

I am Chieftain here. Not Garen Redfang. I have come with my tribes here. I am Chieftain! Show respect!

She said it loudly, letting her voice ring out through the room. Rags stared up at the huge Goblin sitting on his throne fearlessly. The warriors

around them had their hands on their weapons, but she only had eyes for him.

Two crimson eyes blazed in anger. Slowly, ignoring the crossbow trained on him, the Goblin Chieftain stood up. And when he did, Rags realized how huge he was. He was a giant, tall as a Minotaur and bigger still! His voice boomed as he pointed down at Rags, filled with anger.

“I am the Great Chieftain of the North, Tremborag! I met with the Goblin King ten years ago. When he came to Izril, he came to *my* tribe with his armies! I have seen his face. I know his name. Velan the Kind, last King of our people. You dare to come into my domain and challenge me? Know your place. *Kneel!*”

His last word thundered in the cavernous room, and the pressure that hit Rags and the other Goblins had to have been from a Skill. Garen gritted his teeth and grinned fiercely as Goblins around him dropped to one knee or cowered.

Rags felt her legs buckle, but she did not kneel. She looked around and saw most of the other Chieftains kneeling as well. Only three—a tall, female Hob and a normal-sized Goblin, both with the second most powerful tribes after Garen’s, refused to kneel. And, surprisingly, the Gold Rock Chieftain. He stood steadily on his feet, blinking and scratching at a layer of fat as he stared at Tremborag.

The crossbow was heavy in her hands. Rags lowered it, but kept the point trained on Tremborag’s feet.

I am Chieftain too. You offer disrespect! Know *your* place.

Dead silence followed her words. Then Rags heard a voice. Garen, standing behind her, laughed. He laughed loudly, and then spoke to the Great Chieftain.

“See? She is fearless! And she is a Chieftain! My Chieftain.”

That made all the Goblins standing with Tremborag go still with shock. Rags felt countless eyes on her, but stood proudly. She was Chieftain. That could not be taken away from her.

But Tremborag managed to do it with a dismissive glance. He looked at Garen.

“You? Gave way to her? Why?”

The Hob warrior grinned.

“She can lead armies. She is smart.”

As if she wasn't here! And he—Tremborag had the gall to suggest Garen had let Rags defeat him on purpose! The worst part was that he was right. Rags ground her teeth, but the conversation went on and she couldn't break into it.

“A Chieftain to lead warriors while you fight in the front! I see! Clever! I would expect nothing less from Garen Redfang!”

Tremborag laughed hugely as he settled back down on his throne. Garen grinned too, but there was a spark in the air between the two Goblins. They were fighting for dominance, and everyone in the room felt it. The trouble was...well, that it wasn't Rags doing the fighting. And she sensed like all the Goblins that both Garen and Tremborag were matched in their way.

“So. You have a leader and many tribes. Why have you come here, then, Garen Redfang? Did you not swear never to join the Goblin Lord? Did you not fight them, or were you too afraid and fled here?”

From behind Rags she heard Goblins shouting angrily at this—probably Garen's warriors. But the Hob was calm, and replied coolly.

“We did fight. We fought an army. Goblin Lord's army. Thousands strong. We slew them all. But it was warband.”

Silence. All Goblins could understand what this meant. Tremborag lost his grin and nodded. His face grew serious. He looked past Garen, and his voice deepened further, if that were possible.

“When the Goblin King lived, his raiding parties were tens of thousands strong. So I have heard. A Goblin Lord stands second-highest to a King. He is strong.”

“Strong. But he is no true Goblin.”

That came from Garen, and it was damning as it was shocking to hear, even though Rags knew his opinion. Tremborag gazed down at Garen silently, and nodded.

“He is not. But I ask again. Why do you come here, Garen Redfang?”

Everyone knew the answer, but Garen had to say it. He bared his teeth.

“To fight against the Goblin Lord. Together.”

Rags held her breath, forgetting for a moment that it was she who should have made the offer. Tremborag nodded closing his eyes briefly. But when he looked at Garen it was with another one of his smiles, as if he was playing some huge trick on the Hobgoblin.

“You say to ally. But here I sit in my kingdom in the mountain. My Goblins are strong. Why should I ally with you, you who has abandoned his home?”

Now Rags could answer. She opened her mouth, but to her outrage Garen stepped *past* her and spoke in her place. He gestured at her and the Goblins behind him. Rags had her hand on her sword, itching to stab him.

“I am strong. My tribe and other tribes—under Rags—is strong. And she is smart. She can lead armies to battle.”

At least he said that. Tremborag’s eyes focused on Rags briefly again, assessing, discarding.

“So? I have armies and strong and smart warriors of my own.”

Garen nodded. He touched something else, something hidden behind his armor. Rags stared at it, knowing what it had to be. A little key.

“I have something else. A prize. You know what it is.”

Tremborag stared at Garen’s hand. He nodded. Spoke quietly.

“Yes. I know what you have. And that false Goblin to the south shall not have it.”

The two stared at each other for a long minute. Then Tremborag nodded. He rose, and laughed. Then he spread his arms wide.

“So be it! Garen Redfang, we will fight together! This Goblin Lord will not rule us. And he will break his teeth upon this mountain if he should come for battle.”

A moment’s breath as Goblins understood this, and then thunder rang out as hundreds, thousands of voices shouted out. Rags realized the throne room, the banquet room, wasn’t just filled with warriors. Goblins, ones who were lesser warriors or not fighters at all, filled the upper balconies dug out of the rock or stood clustered around the entrance to the throne room.

Garen strode forwards, and he and Tremborag met. They didn’t hug or shake hands, but they stood together and so it was done. Rags knew it. And she also knew something else.

She’d lost her power here. Garen had taken it without a fight and without saying so, but he had taken it from her.

She just didn’t understand *how*.

She confronted him as the banquet room was filling with thousands of Goblins. Tremborag was as good as his word, and he had declared a feast to celebrate. Huge baskets full of food, cooked meat and raw, and many other foods, vats of bubbling soup, were being taken out to feed the hungry mass of Goblins.

Rags wasn't eating just yet. She stopped Garen as he finished peeing in a corner where other Goblins had done the same by the smell of it. He looked at her and grinned.

"Little Chieftain."

That was it. Rags aimed a kick at the thing dangling between his legs. Garen frowned and blocked the blow.

"Painful. Don't do that."

I am Chieftain!

She shouted it at him. Garen just pulled his pants up and shrugged. He looked at her as if he'd done very little wrong; an inconsequential thing she was getting worked up over.

"You are Chieftain. But I am Garen Redfang. And I am strong. So I am Chieftain too, in a way."

"That is not...how...it works!"

Rags hissed at him, practically stumbling over the words. Garen just shook his head.

"You need me. I, Tremborag respects. Not you."

It was true, but it didn't stop Rags from trying to kick him in the same place. Garen just laughed and moved out of the way.

"It is time to eat. Eat, and then we shall talk, Chieftain."

She watched him go, despairing inside. Well, Garen had said it. He wasn't under her command. He just pretended to be because it was convenient. Now she knew. And she...

She had to do something about it. Instantly, Rags stopped thinking of the Redfang tribe as being hers. It was not. Her tribe was smaller now, and weaker. And it was in a place where one tribe reigned supreme.

But she was still Chieftain. Filled with that knowledge, Rags returned to the banquet room. Countless Goblins were tearing at food, eating in groups or alone – as alone as you could get in such a crowded room anyways – but

the place of choice seemed to be reserved for the Goblins sitting at the massive table in front of the dais.

In truth, it didn't make sense to Rags. Goblins didn't use tables! Not unless they had a lot of food and the ground was really dirty, at any rate. And they didn't do...formality. But these Goblins, Tremborag's tribe, had clearly adopted the other species' way of doing things.

It was just another thing that didn't make sense to Rags, but food was food. She walked towards the table. The seats were almost exclusively filled by Hobs. Some elite Goblin warriors of regular size were there too, but it was clearly based on hierarchy. She saw her fellow Chieftains sitting at the table already, halfway up, and Garen at the far end.

But where did she sit? Rags saw a Goblin hurrying to intercept her. They had Goblins waiting on the table? True, Goblins always brought her food if she wanted it, but this—

Rags frowned as the meek Goblin pointed to a place on the table. Far down the table, near the end. It was where some of her warriors sat, including the Still Grass Chieftain. And it was not where she belonged.

Even if Garen and his tribe were not hers, Rags knew she belonged near the head of the table. She looked towards the throne and saw Tremborag, huge and inescapable, sitting there with Garen and a few of his warriors. The Great Chieftain was watching her. He was eating what looked like the entire bloody leg of a cow, and laughing at something Garen had said. But he was staring at her.

He'd put her here. Rags stared at the empty seat waiting for her. It was a deliberate insult, Rags knew. She stared up at the head of the table, where Garen sat next to Tremborag. Rags didn't blush; she didn't feel embarrassed in the slightest. No, the only thing in her heart was anger.

Rags didn't take the seat. She turned from the meek Goblin and strode towards the head of the table, ignoring the looks she got from the other Goblins eating. They were watching her too. Of course they were. Probably most of the room was watching her, seeing what she did. That was Goblins for you. They watched everything. But Rags had never known a day where her actions mattered as much as now.

She stopped at the head of the table and looked around. Garen was sitting next to Tremborag, who was seated at the head of the wide table. And across from him...

"What is wrong, little Goblin? Are you lost? Your seat is over there!"

A Hob, battle-scarred and confident, sat in the chair across from Garen. He was holding some kind of crude mead in his hands—no doubt made in this very mountain—and laughing at her.

Rags just stared at him. She walked over and pointed to his seat.

My seat. Move.

He blinked at her for a second, and then roared with mirth. The Goblins who'd heard Rags laughed as well, as did Tremborag. Garen was smiling and just watching Rags.

She calmly watched the Hob instead. He was laughing at her. So were the other Goblins, Hobs and normal ones alike. They didn't respect her.

Was Rags angry? No. She'd gone far beyond that, into a realm where the words furious, incandescent, and wrathful were the soft option. The pure quill of rage was burning in Rags' chest, which is why she did what she did next without thought for the consequences.

The Hob was still laughing as Rags looked at the table. It was rather high up, so she placed one hand on it. Then she swung herself upwards and stood on the table. Ignoring the dishes, Rags walked across the table, kicking plates out of the way and scattering mugs to the displeasure of their owners. The Hob sitting next to Tremborag blinked at her—

And she kicked him in the face.

It was a good kick. Solid. Rags put her entire body into it. It snapped the Hob's head backwards, and he tipped backwards in his chair. It struck the ground with a thump, spilling him out of it.

And the noise—

Stopped.

Fighting wasn't unusual at any mealtime. Any number of brawls or petty squabbles could break out and Goblins would ignore it or get clear or join in without raising an eyebrow. But this was different.

The entire hall went silent. The Hob surged to his feet, angry.

"You. Weak Goblin female! You challenge *me*?"

Did they all speak the common tongue? Rags stood with both feet planted, ignoring Tremborag's grin and Garen's eyes on her. She stared at the Hob and spoke loud enough for all to hear.

I am Chieftain. This is my seat. Will you fight me?

Silence. The Hob stared at her incredulously. Then he snarled.

“I will beat you and take you for myself. You are weak!”

That was it. The hall, which had already been quiet, went still. He had challenged her, a Chieftain. Normally Tremborag would have stopped him, or supported the Hob, but he wasn’t about to do so, Rags knew.

And in that case, her tribe would defend Rags as their Chieftain. She waited. But heard only silence. Goblin culture demanded her Hobs and elite warriors would rise to her defense. But no one moved. Rags felt her heart freeze over. If they did not follow her—

A chair moved back. The Gold Stone Chieftain, sitting far down the table, stood up lazily, as if he was getting up to stretch his legs or pee. And as Goblins saw him stand, Rags saw the Still Grass Tribe’s Chieftain stand, full of nervous energy.

Three other Hobs stood as well, two females and a male. Three, out of the many she commanded. And the Fire Bite Chieftain remained sitting. But it was enough. Rags stared at the Hob, ready to fight. She would claim her authority right here and now, in blood and death if she had to.

The Hob snarled. He raised a fist and moved towards her. Rags called magic into her hand, ready to burn his face. She wouldn’t use her crossbow here; he was too close. Her sword. She had to prove—

“Rags is my Chieftain.”

Garen Redfang pushed back his chair suddenly. The Hob turned, suddenly wary. Garen smiled, his teeth glinting as he raised his voice.

“My Chieftain. You disrespect her.”

Rags stared with narrowed eyes at Garen. He’d stood up late. He wasn’t supporting her, not in the right way. But it was good for Garen. Now the Hob had to take him on; he couldn’t back down. The warrior hesitated, but then he came at Garen, fist swinging fast at the other Goblin’s head.

Too slow for Garen, though. The other Hob waited until the fist was close to his face before he lashed out. He leaned back and *kicked* the other Goblin in the chest.

Garen hit him so hard Rags could hear the Goblin warrior’s bones *crack*. The Hob stumbled back, sat down. Then he lay down and didn’t get back up.

“Here. Chieftain.”

Politely, Garen pulled back the chair. Rags stared at him in silence. Then, ignoring the fallen Hob who a few smaller Goblins ran over to drag away, she hopped off the table and took a seat.

“Well. You have claimed your seat, and your faithful warrior has protected you. Good!”

Tremborag said the words loudly, and noise resumed as if he had commanded it. He grinned down at Rags, and she saw how he could easily bite her head off with one chomp of his jaws. But she just stared up at him without flinching.

“She is brave. I told you she would not sit there.”

Garen sat back down, grinning as he tore into a bloody piece of meat. Tremborag laughed.

“Yes. You did. Well, we shall talk, little Rags and Garen Redfang. Talk, but only about small things. For now we eat!”

And as he spoke a plate was put in front of Rags. She stared down at it, askance; who used *plates*? The crude, clay plate sat in front of her, insultingly stupid. The table was fine—but she took it anyways. Rags grabbed as much food as she could reach, standing on the table much to Tremborag’s amusement.

And so Rags ate her fill, which was unusual for a Goblin. It usually meant everything was well, but as she found her tribe after the banquet and learned they had been assigned their own part of the stone city, and her Goblins had already been assigned tasks to fulfill, she knew all was not well.

Garen Redfang and Tremborag. Goblin legend, former Gold-rank adventurer and Chieftain. And a Chieftain who ruled over an actual palace, who claimed to be Great Chieftain among Goblins and spoke and acted like a Human.

Rags knew that she could not trust them.
Either of them.

It was dark when Rags was finished familiarizing herself with the new role her tribe was filling in Tremborag’s domain. She didn’t like that her people were being split up, given new roles and places to sleep, as if they

weren't her tribe anymore. She didn't like it, but she knew she couldn't do anything about it right now.

She wanted to get out and explore this place, this massive city that spoke to her of past glories before the Goblins had claimed it. She wanted to learn more about Tremborag and join in on whatever he and Garen were planning. She wanted to think about her tribe and what she was losing or had already lost.

But two figures stopped her at the entrance to her quarters. Rags had her hand on her shortsword, but she stopped when she saw one of them.

The Gold Stone Chieftain stood lazily next to the door, chewing on something. A bone. He was munching it down, marrow and bone and all. Were his teeth made of iron?

Chieftain.

He nodded to her. Rags nodded back, and stared at the other Goblin. He was a Hob, one of hers. Why was he here? Why was the Gold Stone Chieftain here?

I am going.

She wanted to be alone. But the Gold Stone Chieftain just shook his head at her. He tapped his chest slowly, and spoke after a brief pause with a deep frown on his face.

"Should go with. Dangerous...alone."

He had to use another language, because what he was saying was so foreign to Goblins. Rags couldn't believe the implications. She might be attacked? Her? A Chieftain welcomed into another tribe's hold?

She stared at the other Hob and then at the Gold Stone Chieftain. Two Hobs? She needed...?

Slowly, a dark feeling began to steal over Rags. She remembered the Hob's comments, the one she'd kicked, and Tremborag's. She wondered what the Gold Stone Chieftain had seen that made him come here. But she knew one thing.

He was loyal. Rags looked up at the Hob, who'd resumed crunching on his bone. She looked at him, and spoke the words that were in her heart.

This place...is not Goblin. Not Goblin.

She felt it already. The other Hob stirred, but the Gold Stone Chieftain just nodded silently. Rags nodded as well.

They are not Goblin. But I am.

It was a declaration that meant a thousand things, and it was one which meant war if anyone else were to hear. But they were alone. The Hob warrior looked nervous, but he stood with Rags. And the Gold Stone Chieftain just tossed the last bit of bone aside. He didn't say much, but he knew exactly what to say.

“Yes, Chieftain.”

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When she woke up, it was like any ordinary day. But Mrsha knew it was special because she could smell the crepes.

She liked crepes. They were hot and chewy, and sometimes burned when Lyonette made them. Other times they were still runny, but they were always good because they came with honey.

The small Gnoll with white fur sat up in Lyonette's empty bed, wriggling out of the covers she'd stolen again last night. Her short, bushy tail beat the ground hard, and in a few moments she raced downstairs.

Food! It wasn't at all like the bloody meat she used to eat in her tribe's camp, or the hot and filling stews. Those were spiced and tasted good, but they were made for everyone and sometimes there wasn't enough. But here, in this inn that smelled of new wood and strange bug-men, Mrsha could always eat as much as she wanted.

And she could eat honey! The Gnoll drooled as she ran downstairs on all fours. She slipped near the bottom on one of the steps, though. Mrsha made a small sound of alarm, tried to catch her balance, failed, and tumbled down the stairs.

"Mrsha!"

It was the first word of the day, and it was hers. Mrsha uncurled from the protective ball she'd made and looked up. Hurrying across the big, empty room was a familiar face. The Human girl known as Lyonette rushed over to the Gnoll, already fretting out loud.

"Are you hurt? Are you okay? I *told* you not to run down the stairs! Oh, let me check—"

Mrsha turned her face up so Lyonette could see she was well. It was an odd thing the Human girl did, the Gnoll had found. She had to inspect Mrsha all over to see she was well. A Gnoll would have just sniffed to make sure there was no blood—Mrsha had fallen many times over the course of her young life and learned quickly not to cry over small things.

But Lyonette cared. She cared so much that it made Mrsha feel fuzzy inside sometimes. Already the Gnoll knew she'd get extra honey on her crepes—more than she usually got, which was already a lot. Because Lyon

was a nice person. She took care of Mrsha. She took care of the inn while Ryoka and Erin were away.

That was what Mrsha understood. This was Ryoka's home, and the home of the girl who made delicious things. Erin. But it was also Lyonette's home, and she took care of it while they were gone.

It wasn't Mrsha's home. It wasn't. But it was a good place, and it made Mrsha feel happy most of the time. And Lyonette always fed her here, although some of the things she made tasted bad.

She wasn't a good cook. And she fussed about things like the cold and bugs and washing. And she couldn't smell, at least, not like Mrsha could.

But she was kind. She fed Mrsha every day and she always asked Mrsha how she was feeling. She hugged Mrsha often and sometimes cried, but never when she knew Mrsha was around. She smelled of guilt and her hands had blisters from scrubbing and working now.

She was almost as good as a mother. But Mrsha's mother was dead. And her father. And her tribe was dead too, every last one.

She was alone.

The black thoughts broke through Mrsha's happiness suddenly. She sat at one of the tables as Lyonette fussed over her, suddenly filled with emptiness. She remembered.

Perhaps Lyonette noticed Mrsha's suddenly drooping tail and ears, and the way she stared at her white fur. Maybe she didn't. But in the next moment she had—

Crepes!

Mrsha forgot about what she'd been thinking on purpose. Her stomach rumbled and she wagged her tail and panted as the crepes came on a big plate next to a bowl filled with sweet honey. She reached for the first steaming one, but Lyonette grabbed her paw.

"Ah, ah! You know what to do first, Mrsha."

The Gnoll child hesitated, and then saw another empty plate. She pulled it towards her, and Lyonette nodded encouragingly.

"And the silverware?"

Mrsha found a fork and knife as well. She put it next to her plate. Then she looked at Lyonette pleadingly. The girl smiled and nodded.

Instantly, the Gnoll grabbed a crepe off the plate. Ignoring the silverware and her own plate, she bit into it happily. Then she took the bowl of honey and poured some over her plate. She wiped some of the honey

onto her crepe, took another bite. Sweetness and the electric rush of energy made her practically vibrate on her seat.

Sitting next to her, Lyonette laughed and tried to make Mrsha eat 'civilized', which was to say, slower, and with a knife and fork. But Mrsha was too hungry and why should she use a fork? Paws were faster.

That was breakfast, on a day like any other. But it was a good breakfast, and special because she wasn't in the city. It had been nearly a week since Mrsha had left the Drake who made all the rules, Selys. She had come here, to a better place. She might have called it a home, but how could it be?

After she was done, Mrsha sat on her chair, snuffling at Lyonette's plate, wondering if she had room to lick up crumbs or whether Lyonette would let her lick the plate clean. What would happen next?

It was a mystery. Some days Lyonette was busy and she'd go around cleaning up dust or cooking more food. But other days she'd play with Mrsha, or bathe her, or groom her hair. Mrsha had toys now. They were hers; the bossy Drake had given them to her. She wanted to play with the ball outside if Lyonette would throw it. Or maybe she could look at the wriggling thing? It was still sitting in the bowl; Mrsha could smell it. Maybe Lyonette wanted to play in the snow?

But then Mrsha smelled something different. Her head turned towards the stairs, and she went still in sudden fright.

It wasn't a normal day after all. Because coming down the stairs, yawning, was a Drake. Not the bossy Drake, or the one who played chess. Someone else.

Instantly, Mrsha was out of her chair and hiding behind Lyonette. But the girl only stroked her head and smiled at the strange Drake.

"Oh! Mister Shivertail. You're up early."

Shivertail? Mrsha's ears perked up at the words. She looked at the Drake, and remembered that he was the one who'd come last night!

Zel? Mrsha remembered it because she'd never heard of anyone with a 'z' in their name before. Cautiously, she padded around the table and circled Zel Shivertail warily.

"Mrsha! Don't be rude to a guest!"

Lyonette tried to chase Mrsha away, but she was slow. The Drake only laughed though, as he took a seat.

"I don't mind, Mistress. Gnoll cubs are far easier to deal with than Drake hatchlings. Do I smell breakfast?"

“Oh! Let me get you a plate. I’ve made crepes—unless you’d like something else? I can do eggs and bacon...”

Mrsha perked up at the words, although she still felt full.

“Crepes will be fine.”

Lyonette hurried into the kitchen. When she came back with crepes and a glass she hovered around Zel while he ate, making contented sounds and Mrsha padded under the tables and chairs nearby, still watching the Drake and sniffing at him with keen interest.

She remembered something about him, didn’t she? He smelled like the sheets of the inn of course, and she could tell he’d travelled for a while because the odor of dried sweat emanated from his clothes. But there was something else, something familiar...

“I’m sorry, we don’t have anything to drink but milk and water. Um. Are Drake children really so hard to manage?”

“Water is fine—milk would be quite nice if you have it.”

Zel waited until Lyonette came back with a cooled pitcher of milk. Sneaking up on the Drake from behind, Mrsha listened to him talk to Lyonette with one ear as she kept sniffing.

“Children? They’re awful. I’ve never had any, but Drakes at a young age are temperamental and they *bite*. Of course, I hear Gnolls do too, but I’ve never had one of them bite my tail.”

Mrsha stared at Zel’s tail. It was curled around a chair leg. She wondered what it would taste like...

“Oh, well. I wouldn’t know. I’m new here. I mean...”

“It’s quite unusual to see any Humans here. I’m sorry, but I didn’t get the full story last night. You said this inn is run by a Human [Innkeeper] who settled here, didn’t you? But how did you come to be here? Did you move from one of the Human cities?”

Mrsha could hear Lyon hesitate as she crept closer one step at a time. Slowly, stealthily—like she was hunting butterflies. She crept along, towards the Drake’s back so he wouldn’t see her, still smelling something so familiar it hurt...

“It’s a long story.”

“If you have time, I’d like to hear it.”

“You’re not busy?”

“I don’t have anything I have to do right away. My...companion is probably still hungover from last night. I heard him say he’d be drinking the

cold away and I'm not that keen on meeting him in any case. These crepes are quite good with this honey! Are there beehives around Liscor that have popped up in the last few years? I didn't hear of that."

"Oh, well, the bees are...um...it's part of the long story, you see..."

Mrsha rolled her eyes silently; she didn't want to hear a story she already knew! She wanted to hear Ryoka's stories. But it meant both adults weren't paying attention to her. Finally, Mrsha could crawl right behind the Drake's chair.

There it was. The smell. She sniffed very quietly at the Drake's claws. Something was lurking past the ordinary smells of unwashed scale, dirt, sweat, and so on.

Then she smelled the blood, faint and old on his claws and the deeper scents of oil and steel. And she remembered.

He runs out of the swirling snow, armor battered, unarmed. But he runs like a giant, and the Goblins attacking Ryoka and the Gnolls hesitate when they see him. And at his back, an army of Drakes appears as if by magic, howling and shouting with fury as they race towards the Goblins.

The Drake slashes out with his claws and tears through a Goblin wearing black armor as if the Goblin had worn nothing at all. He cuts down another Goblin—a Hob with a battleaxe—and charges onwards. At his side, a Drake with a sword that shines with magic cuts down two Goblins with one slash.

They run past Mrsha, and for a moment her heart leaps in her chest. But the Goblins are everywhere, and then a group of Hobs charges towards them. And she hides in the snow, cowering, wishing everything would go away. She is afraid, paralyzed by terror. Afraid, afraid—

"Mrsha?"

She shook, and then realized Lyonette was staring down at her. For a second Mrsha was still afraid, but then she realized she was in the inn. She felt exhausted, and she stared up at Lyon as the girl looked anxiously at her.

"You were shaking. Are you alright? Why were you hiding underneath the table? You should sit with me."

She reached for Mrsha, but the small Gnoll suddenly lashed out in anger. She nipped at Lyonette's hand and the girl pulled back with a cry of pain.

“Ow! *Mrsha!*”

Filled with hot shame, Mrsha retreated back from the Human girl. She hid by another table. So tired. So afraid! She remembered, and looked past Lyonette to stare at the Drake who was eying her.

He was there. He had been there when she had lost her tribe. He—
He didn’t recognize her. At all. Why?

Because of her fur. Mrsha stared down at her white paws as Lyonette stepped back, looking hurt.

“Sorry about that. I guess Mrsha’s just a bit grumpy today.”

“So I see. I might have upset her—Gnolls can be very territorial. It’s strange though. I’ve never seen a Gnoll with white fur before.”

“Oh? But you’ve heard of Gnolls with white fur? I thought Mrsha was unique.”

The Gnoll backed slowly away from the two as Lyonette turned to Zel eagerly. Her heart was beating too fast and she still felt—he had been there. And because he had been there, Mrsha felt like she was back there, too.

“I’ve heard of it. It’s more of a rumor than anything else, but the Gnolls believe certain colors have meaning. White, for instance, is not a natural color for Gnolls of any tribe.”

“But it means something? Ryoka was saying that she thought it had a meaning, but none of the Gnolls would tell her what it meant.”

“I can tell you what I know, but it’s just rumors...”

Mrsha turned away. She covered her floppy ears with her paws. She did not want to hear. She knew what her fur meant.

It meant her tribe was gone. And it meant it was her fault. Mrsha knew that. She couldn’t deny it, no matter how much she wanted to.

[Last Survivor]. Level 8. That was what the voice had told her. It had told her she was the last.

There was no one left.

The knowledge crushed Mrsha, pressed down on her heart until it seemed like there was no air to breathe, no place to exist. They were dead. Her tribe—the Stone Spears—

Were dead.

Because of her.

It felt like suddenly the world was darker, the ceiling lower. And Mrsha was smaller, and it was hard to breathe. She gasped and trembled underneath her table as voices echoed overhead, weirdly distant.

She had to leave. She had to get out. Mrsha stared towards the door, and then ran for it.

“Mrsha! Where are you going?”

Lyonette turned to the Gnoll as she reached up for the handle. Mrsha froze guiltily, but the girl went on.

“Going to the outhouse? Alright, but come back quickly! And don’t try to crawl down there! Remember last time?”

Mrsha didn’t turn. She just opened the door and escaped into the powdery snow. Immediately the world turned bright and white, and cold. Mrsha with all her fur felt cold, but she didn’t care. At this moment she couldn’t bear to be in the inn, not near the Drake who smelled of death and reminded her of what she’d lost. Mrsha looked around the snowy landscape.

There was only one place to go, really. The city. As young as she was, Mrsha still knew the dangers of being alone in the wilderness. So she began to run through the snow, barely visible in the morning light. She was a white patch of color amid a scene dedicated to the very same color.

So perhaps it was no wonder the Drake on guard on the southern gate didn’t notice her. He was standing at attention, but idly. And he didn’t have the nose of a Gnoll, so Mrsha slipped past him with no effort.

And then she was in the streets, staring around at the buildings curiously, and at the many Drakes and Gnolls—and the few Humans—walking down the streets. A thousand scents assaulted Mrsha’s nose at once, and she breathed out slowly.

Better. She could forget. Only—after a few seconds, Mrsha realized she couldn’t forget. Here too was a bad place that drove her backwards in time. Because of the staring.

They stared at her. Drakes and Gnolls. But while the Drakes did it idly, wondering perhaps whose child Mrsha was, or at her odd fur coloring, the Gnolls were different. They stared and they *knew*.

It was too much to bear, so Mrsha ran again. She ran through the sea of legs, turned down the first alley she came to.

Quiet. Alone. That was what she wanted. She didn’t want—

Mrsha’s claws pulled at her fur. She pulled at it, as if she could get rid of it. Some hairs came out, and she felt pain, but she pulled more out, biting at her fur, savage, angry.

It wasn’t fair! It wasn’t her fault!

But it was. And as the despair flooded over Mrsha again, she thought of home. But home was gone. And the inn wasn't her home. Ryoka wasn't there, and she—

She wanted to go back.

Again and again. It felt like Mrsha was turning in circles, and she chased her tail in the wet alleyway, turning about until she was dizzy and wanted to throw up. But it was better than remembering. Anything was.

What now? She couldn't stay here. Last time she'd run away from Selys, the Watch had found her because she'd tried to hide in alleyways. Mrsha had to go somewhere.

But where? Inn? No. So...

Something swirled on the breeze and Mrsha's nose *twitched* as she caught a scent. Gnolls had powerful noses, but their children had far stronger tracking abilities. And so what Mrsha smelled was faint, mixed with a thousand scents, but she still caught it.

A familiar smell. Someone she knew. Instantly, Mrsha padded out of the alleyway and onto the streets. But she paused then, realizing one thing was giving her away.

She was on all fours. It was faster, but in her tribe Urksh had been teaching her to walk on two legs. Mrsha did this now. It was hard—and slower! But she had to blend in, at least a bit. A Drake [Guardsmen] would stop a Gnoll child who was alone and on all fours, but if she walked like this, they would think she was older.

No one stopped Mrsha as she walked hesitantly down the street, pausing to sniff or steady herself against a wall or passing object. Perhaps the patrolling Watch members she saw would have paid attention to her, but they were too busy eying the Humans.

There were a lot of them in Liscor, or rather, Mrsha saw at least one Human down every street she walked. But that was many for the citizens of Liscor, and Mrsha saw how the pedestrians avoided walking near the Humans, especially the adventurers who walked in groups of their own.

Down the street. And then left—sticking close to a wall to avoid the rumbling wagons that went down the middle. The smell grew stronger the more Mrsha followed it, and soon she was able to identify what it was.

In Mrsha's mind an image of a taciturn Human, sitting in a corner of the inn while Erin chatted to him, surfaced. She blinked in surprise and nearly fell forwards.

She knew him! He was the grumpy Human, the one who smelled like leather and alcohol and arrow glue! Mrsha knew what that smelled like. She'd always hung around [Fletchers] as they made arrows—until they chased her away, that was. But this man was different than the [Hunters] of her tribe. He didn't smell like dead animals, but other things. He killed strange creatures Mrsha could not dream of.

The smell was coming from a big building in front of her. Mrsha blinked up at it. It was an inn, like Erin's but very full of people—all of them seemingly Drakes. But Halrac's scent was coming from within, along with the smells of alcohol and food. Mrsha hesitated. Should she go elsewhere?

But she had nowhere else to go. And she liked the grumpy Human. So Mrsha fearlessly entered the inn full of Drakes. She looked around and immediately found the Humans because they were sitting in a corner of the room, and most of the Drakes had their backs to them.

Mrsha glanced around, but none of the Drakes were looking at her. It was because she had a Skill. [Natural Concealment]. Carefully, she crept over to the table where he sat, arguing with three other Humans.

“—I'm telling you, we shouldn't stand for it!”

He sounded angry. Halrac's voice rasped as he argued with a big man in armor—Mrsha stared at his bulging arms—and a young woman who smelled like cotton and cloth and an old man with a staff who smelled of magic. Magic to Mrsha was the smell of burned ozone, the sharp tang of electricity, and a whiff of something else that defied explanation.

“We paid good coin for those rooms. I don't care if that damned [Innkeeper] is offering us another set of rooms. How do we know he won't kick us out of those as well?”

“Because, Halrac, we pay more than any of his other customers.”

That came from the girl with stitches around her wrists. She smelled of magic too, but it was the cloth scent that came strongly from her that intrigued Mrsha. The Gnoll stared at her as she edged closer to the table, sniffing to see if there were any scraps. Was her entire body made of cotton? That couldn't be right, but that's what it smelled like.

A man with a big, gray beard leaned across the table to pull a plate of the spicy flat cakes the Drakes loved to eat towards him. He took one and ate it as he spoke, sounding wise and calm, or like how Mrsha imagined wise and calm people spoke.

“It cannot be helped. The Drake who came by is a Lord of the Wall. To Drakes, that would be the equivalent of a major [Lord] or one of the Five Families turning up. We should count ourselves fortunate that he didn’t reserve the entire inn.”

“Arrogant bastard. I recognize him—he’s a commander as well. Did you see his arms and weapons? We don’t have enchantments of that quality. If it came to a fight, though—”

“We’re not at war, Halrac.”

That was all the big man said. Mrsha saw the [Scout] slowly nod, although he still looked angry.

“I say we should leave. It’s not worth the coin we’re paying to stay here.”

The girl with stitches and dark skin drawled as she sat back in her chair.

“Say I agree with you. I’m getting tired of being sneered at behind my back too, but where would we go? There aren’t any inns not full to bursting in this city and we can’t kick anyone out, unless we’re willing to pay more than we are now.”

Was she a [Mage]? Mrsha crept a bit further under the table, hiding under Halrac’s chair. She wondered if any of the adventurers would drop some food by accident, or if she could steal a snack. Probably not.

“There’s one inn that’s empty. I told you about it before.”

“Your little watering hole. Right. Well, it can’t be worse than waiting thirty minutes for food to arrive.”

The Stitch-girl made a face. The big man exchanged glances with the man with the beard, and then leaned forwards.

“You told us the [Innkeeper] vanished a while back. Has she returned?”

Halrac shrugged.

“I don’t think so. But there’s still a girl in the inn. A [Barmaid].”

The man with the beard looked amused. Mrsha wondered if it got in his way. Gnolls had fur, but not beards. Wouldn’t it get messy when he drank soup or ate food?

“An inn without an [Innkeeper]. Still fancy moving, Revi?”

Revi, the girl, frowned.

“Maybe. It’s empty, you said?”

Halrac nodded. The big man looked unconvinced.

“If the beds are empty, it’s probably for a good reason.”

The [Scout] rolled his eyes expressively. He jerked a thumb at a passing [Barmaid]—who glared at him behind his back.

“A place to sleep—even if it does mean we don’t get waited on hand and foot—is still better than paying ten times as much to be stared at like we’re pariahs.”

“Fine.”

Revi sighed. She looked at the man with the beard.

“Typhenous?”

Beard man paused and stroked said beard.

“I wouldn’t mind a bit more inconvenience if it means cheaper rates. If we’re planning to stay for as long as I fear we are, we should attempt to conserve our coin.”

Revi and Halrac nodded; all eyes turned towards the big man.

“Ulrien?”

“I don’t really care.”

His voice was deep. Mrsha could smell blood on him—not a fresh wound, but the traces of it. She knew this because she was staring right at one amazingly muscled calf. She longed to poke it, but she knew she had to be quiet.

And then—noise! Footsteps approaching. And silence—an audible drop in the background babble of the inn. Mrsha peeked out from her table and immediately hid when she saw the other three beings approaching. She didn’t think they were Human.

“Jelaqua.”

“Ulrien. Is there room at your table for us to sit?”

Mrsha, curled tightly around the center of the table, heard Ulrien reply after a moment of hesitation.

“I don’t see why not. We’ll have to grab chairs and move—”

“Watch the Gnoll cub or you’ll squish her.”

Mrsha froze in surprise. She heard a rustle, and then Halrac’s glaring face peeked below the edge of the table with the other three adventurers. They all looked surprised, and the...woman...named Ivirith laughed.

“You didn’t notice the Gnoll child? You’re losing your touch, Halrac.”

“I didn’t think we’d be spied upon. You there...Gnoll! Come on out!”

Cautiously, Mrsha did just that. She stared up and immediately shrank back when she saw the newcomers. But they didn’t look *angry*...

“Halrac, you know this Gnoll?”

“She’s from the inn. I don’t know why she’s here.”

“Perhaps she’s grown attached to you. I have heard of stranger things.”

The weird-echoing voice came from one of the new adventurers. He looked like he was part crab or part...Mrsha had never seen anything like him before. She stared wide-eyed at the man, before looking *up* at the giant whose head was nearly touching the rafters.

“What do we do with her? I don’t suppose the [Innkeeper] would summon the Watch to bring her home.”

Revi frowned at Mrsha, and then smiled. Mrsha glared at her; she could tell when adults were pretending to be nice!

“Where are you from, little one? Shouldn’t you be going home?”

“She’s mute, Revi.”

The Stitch-Girl drew back and sighed.

“Pity.”

“Oh, let her sit here. Where are those chairs? Oh, thank you, Moore.”

The half-Giant casually lifted the chairs over. Mrsha blinked at her seat, but then sat in it. Her head barely peeked over the table. She stared, wide-eyed at the one who had spoken.

A woman with dead-white skin stared back at her, lips turned upwards in a smile. But Mrsha didn’t smile back.

The woman was *dead*. Mrsha could smell it on her. She was dead, but *something* lived inside her. It was frightening, and Mrsha edged away from the dead woman as she reached out to pet Mrsha on the head.

“Keep away from her, Jelaqua. You’ll scare her.”

Halrac said this irritably, catching Jelaqua’s hand. She glanced at him in annoyance, then looked at Mrsha’s wide eyes.

Jelaqua stopped, sighed, and withdrew her hand. She smelled like death, but she still moved as if she were alive. Mrsha’s fur stood up on end as she scooted her chair away towards Halrac’s seat.

“Aw, don’t be like that little Gnoll. You’re the only one of your kind who hasn’t walked twenty paces wide of me since I’ve been here.”

The woman pulled the plate of snacks across the table and pushed it gently towards Mrsha. The Gnoll hesitated, and then grabbed one greedily. Breakfast seemed an age ago.

“Here. Have one of these. And—[Barmaid]! Drinks for the table, if you would! Ale!”

The pale woman turned and called out to a passing Drake, who nodded, eyes wide as she stared at the woman. Unperturbed, Jelaqua turned back and nodded to Ulrien.

“We’ll pay for what we order, don’t worry.”

Ulrien waved a big hand.

“Forget it. Coin for food and drink is hardly something Gold-rank adventurers need to worry about.”

Jelaqua paused, and then nodded her head to him with a wry smile.

“We’re used to arguments over it. And with how much Moore can drink, well, it’s good to get that out of the way, especially when we’re trying to negotiate.”

“Negotiate? About what?”

Halrac stared suspiciously at the three adventurers. Typhenous rolled his eyes and stroked his beard with one hand.

“There can be only one thing. The dungeon.”

Jelaqua nodded.

“Of course.”

“If you think we’ll give up our claim—”

“Halrac.”

Ulrien’s word silenced the [Scout]. Jelaqua shook her head.

“We’re not here for that. Rather, we’d like to team up.”

“Really?”

The adventurers on Halrac’s side seemed surprised, although Mrsha didn’t understand what was actually happening.

“It’s only practical. It’s too dangerous by ourselves.”

That came from the huge giant, Moore. He had a surprisingly soft voice and he nibbled at one of the doughy discs very carefully.

“We’ve gotten scratched up twice going in there. Both times we didn’t have the numbers for a clean fight. And I’ve heard every other team that’s gone in has run into all sorts of hellish traps, same as us. Those that make it out, that is. If we want to make real progress, we need to work together.”

“Seborn is right.”

Jelaqua took a mug from the tray the Drake [Barmaid] was carrying, ignoring the way the Drake flinched as she stared at the Selphid. Jelaqua took a drink, grimaced.

“Dead gods. This isn’t good stuff. How much do you pay to stay at this inn? Anyways, the last time we went into the dungeon we ran into a pit trap the length of the entire corridor and fifty feet down. If Moore hadn’t cast a spell we’d be dead. But after we landed—guess what was at the bottom of the pit? A colony of Metalbite Slimes.”

Halrac and the other adventurers made noises of dismay. Ulrien shook his head.

“That’s...bad.”

Jelaqua drained the rest of her mug, grimacing. She did not call for a refill.

“Right? But I’ll bet you ran into just as bad a trap. Did you see what chased the last group of adventurers out? The Children. There are entire colonies of monsters in that dungeon, branching pathways that seem to change each time we go in, and traps both magical and mundane—we can’t handle it alone. The Halfseekers are already understrength, but we thought if we combined forces we might stand a chance of getting somewhere in this dungeon. What do you think?”

The team of Griffin Hunt turned and conferred silently. After a moment, Ulrien nodded.

“We could use the extra help.”

Typhenous and Revi both nodded. All eyes turned to Halrac, including Mrsha’s. Revi frowned at him; the [Scout] did not look happy as he shifted his attention between the three half-Humans.

“Halrac?”

He grimaced.

“I have no reason to object. My [Dangersense] is screaming at me every step I take inside that place. Someone else to check for traps would help.”

All the adventurers relaxed. Jelaqua smiled, and Seborn nodded at Halrac soberly.

“Even together, I fear that we will not progress quickly. But it will be reassuring to work with another expert.”

“A team, then. We can haggle over distribution of spoils later—”

“No need. We’ll split it evenly.”

Jelaqua’s brows rose in surprise, but then she was smiling as she clasped hands with Ulrien over the table. She looked around the inn and sighed.

“I’m relieved. If I’d known you would be so open to the idea I would have come earlier. A team. It’s been a long time since our group joined

forces with any other party. On that note—do you know if this inn has any openings? We just got kicked out of ours.”

“Really? Why?”

“You have to ask?”

All three Halfseekers smiled crookedly. Mrsha wriggled in her seat. She was getting bored! She watched Jelaqua’s pale lips moving, wondering why she didn’t rot when she was dead.

“Selphids aren’t popular on Izril—less so than Baleros, incredibly. All the rumors about my kind lead to suspicion and paranoia. As for Moore... someone with a quarter of a Giant’s blood in him is hard to feed, let alone find a bed for. Oh, and apparently Seborn smells like fish.”

“Untrue. But arguing doesn’t help matters.”

Mrsha’s stomach rumbled. She probably shouldn’t have eaten so much. But it was so tasty! She looked around as the adventurers spoke about boring things.

“We just got kicked out of the best rooms in this inn too. No help here, I’m afraid. But Halrac’s been telling us to visit another inn—you know, the one outside the city where we had that—”

“Really? Do you think it’s still empty? I was wary of being outside, especially since it seemed like there was some drama to do with the Gnolls. And that skeleton! But if we’ve no other choice—it would be good to work under the same roof...”

Mrsha was powerfully curious about the Halfseekers, it was true. She’d love nothing more than to sniff at Seborn and Moore, but she knew it wouldn’t be polite. She could sit here and eat more food maybe, but—she didn’t want to sit here! Now that she’d been caught, the fun was over. Mrsha wriggled in her seat, and looked towards the open doors. Time to go. She grabbed another spicy, doughy treat and slipped off her chair.

“Hey now. Where are you going young Miss?”

The big half-Giant, Moore, turned to Mrsha and she froze. But he looked concerned rather than angry. Mrsha edged away from him, ready to bolt, but Halrac stopped Moore as the half-Giant moved to rise.

“Leave her. The last thing we need to be accused of is harassing a child. The inn’s not far from here and the streets are safe.”

“But is the inn safe? I would hate for a child to be put in danger. The monsters around the city can be dangerous, especially if some escape from the dungeon. It is waking up.”

“The Watch patrols, and they’re as good as—better than teams of Silver-rank adventurers. I saw one of them—a Drake. He knows how to fight!”

Seborn frowned at Jelaqua, although only the fleshy half of his face moved.

“They patrol within the city. But if you’re really suggesting we sleep outside of it—are there any guards in this inn, any enchantments? Or will we be sleeping with one ear to the ground?”

Mrsha scampered out of the inn as the adventurers continued to argue. She didn’t know what they were talking about. Mrsha seldom did. But they were busy and Halrac seemed sad. He always seemed sad, which is why Mrsha felt a bit drawn to him.

Maybe he knew what being alone was like.

Disappointed and lonely, Mrsha wandered back onto the street. There she remembered why she’d gone inside. The Gnolls stared at her. A passing trio of Drakes—a child and mother and father slowed as they saw Mrsha. The child pointed to her.

“Why is her fur white?”

Because she was the last. Mrsha turned and ran down the street. Where now? Back?

No—there was someone else. The bossy Drake. She would be nice to Mrsha. The Gnoll raised her nose to the air and sniffed.

There? No—there? It was hard to pick out her smell on the streets. Mrsha would have to search to find her.

But something else smelled familiar to her. Mrsha looked up and saw a familiar person.

Pawn! The Antinium was walking down the street. Mrsha immediately ran after him, but he had a lead on her and it was hard for her to follow through the crowds of people. When she did catch up with him, she found herself on an abandoned street—

And staring down into a hole in the ground. That was what it looked like. Suddenly, an entire street just...vanished. The cobblestones ended, and a sloping path of dirt led down into darkness. Mrsha halted on the edge of it, uncertain. Strange smells were coming from below—the same smells as that of the huge Soldiers who’d come from the inn.

But Pawn had gone down there, she knew. And the Soldiers were nice! So, bold and unafraid, Mrsha ran down the dirt tunnel, into the darkness.

It wasn't fully dark. Glowing patches of moss lit up the tunnel immediately, but it was still far too dark for a Human to see. Mrsha could see just fine though. She ran forwards eagerly, but froze when she realized she was surrounded.

Standing in the walls, huge, silent, were Soldiers. They stepped out as one, clenching their fists in a clear sign of aggression. Mrsha backed up as she saw more Soldiers appearing *behind* her! It was a trap!

The Soldiers were ready to kill, but not ready for the sight of a small Gnoll. They stared at her. But then they started forwards again, hostile, and so Mrsha ran.

She ran. The wrong way, as it turned out. In order to get away from the looming Soldiers Mrsha had to race into the dark tunnels. They chased after her, but while they could have blocked a Human, Drake, or any other species quite easily, Mrsha was too small and slipped between their legs. She dashed forwards—

And found herself in a huge network of tunnels, filled with shadows in the dim illumination. Crisscrossing openings, paths leading up and down—

And Antinium. Hundreds of them, all marching in an unending current. Mrsha froze as they all turned and stared at her. A group of Soldiers turned towards her, and she heard the ones behind her running. Mrsha dashed forwards, unthinking, and hurtled down a tunnel, past Workers who stood aside from her.

Where was she going? Away! Mrsha had no idea where she was, she just ran from all the Antinium she could see, especially the soldiers.

Left, left, right! A dark shadow came out of a side passage—Mrsha turned the other way.

She ran downwards, then right, took another right, and another—but she wasn't where she'd started when she turned right again. Instead, she found a opening at the end of the passageway. Mrsha ran through it, too frightened to stop—

And found herself in a gargantuan room, staring up at the Queen of the Free Antinium under Liscor. The massive Antinium—more insectile than humanoid—paused as she lifted a morsel of what might have been food to her mouth with feelers.

“What is this?”

Soldiers. They appeared next to Mrsha. They'd been guarding the doorway! She turned to run, but they were blocking the entrance, boxing

her in! Their hands were raised to bludgeon her to death, but a deep feminine voice rumbled.

“Hold.”

The Soldiers froze instantly. Mrsha raised her head cautiously; she’d been cowering on the ground. She turned to the Queen, and heard a rumble like a sigh.

“Child of Gnolls. You should not be here.”

Carefully, Mrsha padded forwards. The Queen’s full body was obscured in the partial darkness. Mrsha only had the impression of a bulbous, huge abdomen and...body parts that were feelers and antennae rather than arms and legs.

“So now the people living here are fearless enough to let their young intrude into the Hive? I should feel glad—but I do not. Only death awaits trespassers here. You should know that child, or your parents should.”

Mrsha could only hold still as the massive presence regarded her.

“White fur? How intriguing.”

She knew. Mrsha bowed her head. In this place, she couldn’t run. Her ears perked up as she heard hammering footsteps, and then another Antinium ran into the room. He had to pause—the Soldiers barred his way, but after the Queen gestured, they moved aside smoothly. She recognized Klbkch on sight.

“My Queen! I arrived as soon as I heard of the intrusion. Where is—”

He stopped when he saw Mrsha.

“You?”

“You know this Gnoll, Klbkch?”

“She belongs at the inn, my Queen.”

“The one with the girl Erin Solstice.”

Another sigh echoed throughout the room. Mrsha saw Klbkch staring at her. He slowly walked in front of Mrsha as if shielding her.

“It seems this innkeeper causes trouble even when she is not here.”

“This child does not know the rules of Liscor, my Queen. I am sure her trespass was accidental.”

“Perhaps. But the rules must be kept. Make sure other visitors to the city are aware of this. And this Gnoll...”

Again, Mrsha felt the Queen staring at her, and this time it was with more than a hint of malice. She trembled, hiding behind Klbkch, feeling the need to pee.

“I am sure the citizens of Liscor would be greatly disturbed if she were to be harmed.”

“I am not a fool, Klbkchhezeim. Very well, take the Gnoll cub away. But while you are here—tell me, what do the others do?”

Klbkch relaxed slightly. He bowed his head towards the Queen.

“Nothing, as of yet. They are resting. It has been a long journey; some marched for over a week with little rest.”

“Hm. You are attending to their needs?”

“Of course.”

“...Xrn is here.”

The name meant nothing to Mrsha, but she saw how Klbkch’s posture changed when he heard it. He nodded.

“Her presence is extraordinary. But perhaps it is a sign that the Grand Queen is open to your ideas at last?”

“Or perhaps she has directed her attention here for another reason. Perhaps she seeks you, Klbkchhezeim.”

Silence from the Antinium in front of Mrsha. She saw the Antinium Queen shift posture, heard her voice deepen ominously.

“She cannot have you. The Grand Queen will not take you from me, Klbkch. My Slayer.”

“I am loyal.”

That was all Klbkch said, but it was not enough. Mrsha felt so. The Queen’s voice was almost hesitant as she addressed the Revalantor of her hive.

“Ah, Klbkch. You say that, but...do you regret it? Do you regret that we fled while the others stayed and fought? Do you think we wasted the lives of your brothers and sisters, that we have failed in the long years since arriving here?”

For a long while he was silent. Klbkch looked down at his feet, and then up at his Queen. When he replied, it was softly.

“You have done well, my Queen. You and the others. You rebuilt with what you had; I cannot begrudge that. I only regret that I was too weak to finish the battle on Rhir. It is myself I blame.”

Then he turned, and walked out of the vast room. Mrsha turned to look back just once; she saw the Queen had her head bowed. Then she walked faster to catch up with Klbkch. Mrsha had a bad feeling in her stomach. She wondered exactly how much trouble she was in.

“She was lucky she was not killed.”

Klbkch said that to Krshia as the Gnoll [Shopkeeper] glared at Mrsha. The Gnoll cub had tears in her eyes; a spanking did that to her, and Gnolls didn’t believe in light punishments. Now Krshia was letting Mrsha lie on her front while she and Klbkch sat around her table on two couches.

“I am grateful, yes, that you were here, Klbkch. I shudder to think what would have happened otherwise.”

The Gnoll bowed her head deeply and poked Mrsha *hard*. Mrsha sat up and bowed her head too, rubbing at her stinging bottom.

“I have brought her to you so that you may impress upon her that venturing into the Hive is dangerous. I do not know if she fully understands me.”

“She understands. And if she does not understand fully how foolish she was, she will remember the spanking, yes?”

Krshia glared at Mrsha and the Gnoll immediately nodded her head. Klbkch stared at her, and then looked at Krshia.

“I have noticed her unique coloration. I have also noticed how other Gnolls react to her fur. What does it mean?”

Antinium did not do small talk. Nor did they care about feelings. Or rather, they found them hard to understand sometimes. Mrsha froze, but it was Krshia who put a gentle hand on Mrsha’s head. She stroked Mrsha gently, and the Gnoll relaxed, feeling a familiar presence of a Gnoll adult reassuring her. But it still hurt because it was not the same.

“You ask about things which are not easy to discuss, Klbkch.”

“Yes.”

“Hr. Well then. The white fur is a mark of fate, dire fate, to Gnolls. Some claim it is a curse. Others—a sign of disaster. Those who look so bring misfortune to their tribes and all they encounter, or so it is said, yes?”

“I see. And is it true?”

Krshia shrugged. Mrsha stirred, looking at her face, but the Gnoll’s expression was calm, if slightly troubled.

“How can we know? Some, a few, are born with the fur, and others... others lose their color after terrible things occur. Like Mrsha. Did they

cause it or not? I do not know, but my people fear such individuals regardless.”

“Ah.”

Klbkch ate a cube of raw meat and said little else. Krshia eyed him, and then muttered.

“Myself, I think it is just superstition. The Stone Spears tribe were doomed the instant a Goblin Lord led his army upon them, regardless of fate. Young Mrsha should know this as well, but other, more foolish Gnolls will say differently.”

“It is well that she stays outside the city then. Can you ensure no one tries to attack Mrsha, or is this a matter for the Watch?”

“I will ensure it. No Gnoll will slay another Gnoll while I live.”

Krshia growled the words and Mrsha felt better. Klbkch nodded, and they fell silent again. She sensed that the two of them weren’t losing track of the conversation as much as understanding things silently.

“How is business?”

“I rebuild. Slowly.”

“But I gather from your words that your authority among the Gnolls within Liscor is lessened due to recent events. Is this so?”

“I wait for Ryoka Griffin to return. She has something promised to me, and until it arrives I remain...antsy. As do the Gnolls who listen to me. But I have my paws full in the meantime. I must run a shop regardless if it is smaller, and I have a worthless nephew to take care of.”

“Indeed?”

“Yes. I wonder, since you are here. Would you be willing to take a look at him? He is suffering, and it may be the Antinium can provide aid.”

“It may be so. Is he here?”

“Resting. *Brunkr!*”

Krshia raised her voice and called out. Mrsha went very, very still when she heard the name. She hadn’t seen the Gnoll—Krshia’s cousin and warrior of the Silverfang tribe—since...

A door opened slowly in Krshia’s apartment. Mrsha immediately smelled something bad. She tried to get up, but Krshia gently held her on the couch. Klbkch turned as Brunkr entered the room.

The Gnoll warrior was tall, powerful, a classic tribal warrior. Or at least, he had been. The sweaty, unkempt figure that reeked of rot was foreign to

Mrsha, and as he stumbled into the room, she heard Krshia snort. Because Brunkr reeked, and the odor was not pleasant.

“Ah. You are injured.”

He smelled like sweat and pain, and something worse. Mrsha backed away as she located the source of the foul odor. Brunkr clutched at his hand, oozing, raw, a foul odor coming from beneath the layers of bandages wrapped around it.

“Aunt. Who is this?”

“A [Guardsmen] of the Watch and warrior of the Antinium. He is important, yes? Be respectful.”

Brunkr focused on Klbkch. He nodded slowly.

“I am Brunkr. And I am injured. My hand was bitten. Now...”

He raised his infected hand.

“If I had a quality healing potion—or if my Aunt would buy me one—I would be able to test you in battle, Antinium.”

“Fool! A healing potion will do you no good, no. Rest and cleansing is all we can do now, unless the [Healer] I have asked for will brave the roads.”

Brunkr made a disgusted noise. He was clearly sick. His eyes were unfocused—he didn’t seem to have noticed Mrsha yet.

In his seat, Klbkch nodded at Brunkr.

“A healing potion cannot heal an infection. Miss Krshia is correct. It will only exacerbate the symptoms.”

“Can you help him?”

Krshia looked concerned, for all she snapped at Brunkr to sit and stop messing about. The male Gnoll did so, collapsing onto his seat and grimacing as he held his hand again. Klbkch hesitated, and then shook his head in regret.

“There are serums and substances the Antinium use, but they do not have the same effect on other species. Would a [Healer] not—”

“There are none. None who can help me. The first I brought my hand to said I should burn the wound. I did. But it grew worse, and the others—they tell me it is too late.”

Brunkr gritted his teeth. His eyes refocused, and he stared around, and finally saw Mrsha. His face twisted into a snarl and he surged to his feet.

“You. Doombringer! See what you’ve *done*?”

Mrsha tore away from Krshia in a panic as Brunkr lurched towards her. Instantly, Krshia and Klbkch were on their feet. Both held Brunkr down and made him sit.

“Nephew. You forget yourself! She is a child!”

“Please calm yourself, Brunkr.”

“She did this! *She!* She has taken my hand, just like she took her tribe. Cursed one! Deathbringer! *Calamity!*”

The words broke something deep in Mrsha’s heart. She had felt it all day, but hearing it now was too much. It was all true. She couldn’t run from it no matter how hard she tried.

But she did try. Mrsha turned and leapt off the couch. Krshia grabbed for her, but the Gnoll was too slow. Mrsha dodged around her and the Antinium, who spun and tried to scoop her up. She ran between his legs and though he turned and nearly had her, he wasn’t ready for her to leap *off* of Krshia’s balcony.

Mrsha landed heavily on all fours. It hurt, but she raced off, ignoring Krshia’s shouts for her to come back. She ran and ran. But she could not outrun the truth.

Mrsha cried as she left the city behind. Brunkr’s words cut at her. The Gnoll’s stares pierced her. And the words haunted her.

[Last Survivor]. Level 8. As if she’d asked for this. As if it was a reward.

She just wanted to go back. Back to the inn, where Ryoka would be waiting. Then the girl could tell her a story and Mrsha could—could—

Could pretend she was back home. Her real home, where the fires burned bright every night and where she knew everyone. Where she could run about with the other children and play until Urksh yelled at her. If she could go back, she never would have gone to help gather herbs. She would have stayed in the camp forever, and the Goblins would never have found her. They would never have come and everything would be fine.

Her vision was blurry, but it didn’t matter. Mrsha could smell where she was going. She ran up the hill, towards the inn.

And then away from it. Not there either. She couldn’t be near the Drake, or Lyon with her concern and *caring*.

The past tugged at Mrsha. Seeing other Gnolls reminded her of the people she'd never see again. So she ran far from them, into the snowy landscape, up hills and down valleys, heedless of the danger.

It was a long time before Mrsha finally collapsed, too tired to move any more. She lay in the snow, panting.

No home. Nowhere to go back to. The inn? It wasn't—Mrsha's heart hurt. Lyonette wasn't—

Those who cared about Mrsha got hurt. Or died. Like Ryoka. She'd lost her fingers. She'd gotten hurt for Mrsha and the tribe had died because she'd fallen. Mrsha knew it.

Everyone who tried to help Mrsha died. That was why Ryoka had left. She had left so she wouldn't die. Because Mrsha wasn't worth saving.

The Gnoll curled up in the snow, still crying. It was all her fault. All hers.

She barely heard the crunching of snow before the sound was right on top of her. Mrsha uncurled and stared around as she heard the faltering footsteps approaching. She looked around, bewildered, seeing nothing against the white snow.

Then she saw him. Slowly tripping towards her. Stumbling, faltering. Almost falling down. But still in one piece. Still alive.

Toren.

The skeleton looked almost like Brunkr in the way he moved. It was as if he was exhausted, if an undead being could be tired. He seemed as if he would fall apart at any moment.

But the purple flames in his eyes still burned in their sockets. The fire was weak, guttering. But it burned brighter when Toren saw Mrsha. And it was hatred that filled the young Gnoll with terror.

She turned to run. She heard the skeleton rush forwards, but she was dashing away as fast as she could. She raced up a hill and knew the skeleton was in hot pursuit.

Run, run. As fast as you can. But Mrsha had run so far today, and she was exhausted. She slipped going over the crest of a hill, and tumbled down. She scrambled to her feet, and ran forwards—

And nearly fell into the rift in the earth. It was dark, a gaping fissure made nearly invisible by the slight incline in the snow. Mrsha scrambled away from it—

But Toren was right behind her. The skeleton had a bared sword in his hands. He advanced towards her, swinging the sword menacingly. Mrsha backed up, the chasm behind her. She tried to watch Toren and the opening, but he was moving too quick. Mrsha backed up another step and her back paw slipped.

She slid backwards. Mrsha grabbed desperately, and her paws latched onto something beneath the powdered snow. Toren halted, sword in hand, staring at Mrsha as she dangled over the abyss.

Mrsha's eyes were wide, her arms straining as she tried to hold on. She could barely keep her grip, let alone haul herself up. And the skeleton was just standing there. Just watching her.

He had lowered the sword in his hands. He walked forwards, until he stood right above Mrsha. She waited for him to stab her, but the skeleton just stared down at her.

As if thinking.

And Mrsha wished Ryoka were here. But she knew the girl had left. Gone, far away.

Just like everyone else.

She wanted to go home. But home was gone. And she was alone.

Maybe it was fate. Mrsha felt her claws loosening their grip as the snow fell around her. The skeleton was just staring at her, sword in hand. He took a step forwards.

Chased by bad things. Falling. It was how it had happened last time. But there was no Ryoka anymore. She'd left Mrsha too. And that was a good thing. Because she could not suffer because of Mrsha.

All her fault. White fur. Cursed one. Doombringer. [Last Survivor]. Mrsha sighed. She looked up at the sky.

And then she let go. For a moment she saw the skeleton staring at her, the flames in its purple eyes flickering. It reached out—

But too slowly. The world dropped away from Mrsha and she was tumbling, down, down, into the darkness. The air whistled around her and she closed her eyes.

Mrsha fell.

“Mrsha?”

Lyon searched the inn, but she couldn't find the Gnoll. She tried the outhouse, but Mrsha's tracks led away from there. She ran through the snow. She went to the gates—tried to get in. But Mrsha had left the city. She'd disappeared.

The girl searched. Mrsha was gone. But Lyonette kept searching. She went out into the wilderness and called for the Gnoll until she'd lost her voice. As the cold numbed her, Lyonette kept looking.

"Mrsha? *Mrsha!* Are you there?"

"Where are you?"

It was dark when Mrsha woke up. Dark. Hot. Everything hurt. She cried out. It was the first sound she'd made in a long time. She couldn't move. She hurt.

And someone was calling for her. Mrsha heard the voice, carried by the wind. A familiar voice.

She wanted to call to it. But something stopped her.

Fear. If she called out the voice would die.

She couldn't do that. Better to die here.

But it hurt. Mrsha cried. She tried to move. Something was around her. Bad things lurked in the darkness. They were coming.

She had to run. But the voice. Only the voice could save her.

Mrsha looked up. The light was so far away. It seemed like a memory. But she believed the light, the sky was still there.

She wanted to be saved. Mrsha wept. Even if it meant—she just wanted to live.

So she raised her head. Mrsha took a breath and *howled*. The sound was wordless. It echoed in the dark place she'd fallen into, the dungeon. It went through the skeleton who stood in the darkness, watching her. It travelled up through the rift in the earth and went into the sky.

And Lyonette heard her. Mrsha knew that. She howled and howled, calling out. For salvation. For forgiveness. For another chance.

For life instead of death.

And then she ran, because the things were chasing her. But Mrsha believed she would be saved. She clung to it. That word she barely

understood. That feeling in her that was all that stood between her and despair, her and the darkness.

Hope.

They stopped her at the gates, a Gnoll and a Drake. But she battered at them with her hands, screamed.

“You *have* to let me in! I need adventurers! I need help!”

But they held her back. The Gnoll’s face was openly hostile, the Drake’s put upon. They spoke to her, but Lyonette didn’t care.

“*Please!* Mrsha—she’s down there!”

They didn’t understand. They tried to take her away, force her back. Lyonette hit them. She bit and struggled—even when the Gnoll unsheathed his sword. She would have taken it through her heart if it meant someone would listen.

But the hand that closed over the Gnoll’s arm and pulled the sword away required no sacrifice. Zel Shivertail looked down at Lyon as the Drake [Guardsmen] gaped in awe.

“Tell me what’s wrong.”

The Drake [General] strode through the streets when he heard what had happened. He brought Lyon into the city and summoned the Watch. She ran to the Adventurer’s Guild.

No one there would help her. No one, but a [Scout] who raised his head when he heard her plea. He left his group, and someone came with him.

The Watch called out for aid. They found it. Klbkch walked down into his Hive and spoke to someone waiting there. She and he walked towards the surface.

Lyonette was hurrying towards the gates when the Gnolls appeared. She was afraid, but one of them walked towards her. Krshia had no love for Lyon, but the bow in her hands was not meant for the girl.

And so Lyonette ran through the snow, followed by six people. Six. She prayed it was enough, but there was no time to ask for others. She ran desperately, heart pounding out of her chest. Iron was in her mouth; she

seemed to breathe fire each time she inhaled. But she ran faster so that she would be fast enough.

“There.”

She almost cried as she pointed down into the crevice. Zel stared at it grimly.

“Deep. That’s at least a hundred feet down—”

“Far more.”

Halrac stared into the darkness, face grim. He turned to Lyonette.

“Are you sure you heard her down there? If she fell—”

“I’m sure. Please, you have to help!”

“The dungeon is down there.”

Klbbkch said the words flatly. Halrac and Zel stared at him, one in alarm, the other confused.

“The dungeon? Are you sure?”

“Yes. This place—the location matches a part of the dungeon. And I believe it goes straight down into the heart of it.”

“We can’t go down there unprepared. It would be suicide.”

Halrac bit his lip hard enough to draw blood as he said it. Lyonette stared at him in desperation. But the woman standing next to Halrac gritted her teeth.

“The hell we can’t. I’m going, if you can tie that rope to something secure. No—don’t bother. Just hold it as I go down, Halrac.”

Jelaqua Ivirith hefted the two-handed flail in her hands as she stared at the dungeon grimly. Zel eyed her.

“Aren’t you a Selphid?”

“So?”

She glanced at him challengingly.

“I have a soft spot for children, and those shunned by others. And it seems like this young Gnoll is both. Let me help find her; I’m a Level 33 [Iron Tempest].”

“What class is that?”

“It’s a class derived from [Flailmaster]. I have the Skills to fight a pack of foes at once, if that’s what’s lurking down there. Are you coming or not?”

“I will go.”

Zel nodded at once. Lyonette was nearly in tears—he gripped her hands reassuringly.

“I will enter as well.”

“As will I.”

Two Antinium said that. Klbkch, and an azure one Lyonette had never seen before. She held a staff in her hands and watched Zel as carefully as he ignored her. She inclined her head to him.

“Zel Shivertail. Will you permit me to lend my aid here?”

“Just this once, I will accept your help.”

He said the words coldly as he stared into the darkness. Zel turned.

“Can we anchor the rope to something? Let’s move! Mrsha could be in danger as we speak.”

“Almost done.”

Krshia was helping Halrac fix anchors in the ground for the rope they’d brought. She stood up, bow in hand, and nodded to the rope.

“We will have to hold on, very tightly, going down. Or else we will fall.”

“No need for that. I will cast a [Featherfall] spell and slow us.”

The mysterious Antinium said that. The others looked at her in surprise; none of the others had realized she was a mage.

“Going up will be slower, then.”

“Up can be slow as it must. Down is most important. So let us hurry, no?”

Klkbch hesitated as he looked at Krshia.

“Are you sure you wish to risk this, Miss Krshia? The danger—”

She bared her teeth at him and he shut up.

“She is in danger, and my responsibility. At least in part. I will go.”

“Gather around me.”

Zel, Jelaqua, Klbkch, and Krshia did as Xrn ordered. Jelaqua glanced sideways, and grinned at Halrac.

“Change of heart?”

He just shrugged, face grim.

“If I’d have known we were going into the dungeon, I would have brought everyone. Girl, go back into the city and tell them what’s happened.”

“I will. Thank you! Please—bring her back!”

“We will.”

Several of them said it at the same time. The group looked around and Zel had to bare his teeth ruefully.

“It occurs to me I don’t know who any of you are. Well, the non-Antinium at any rate.”

“Indeed. I hesitate to suggest this, but some of us are more capable than others.”

Klbkch nodded at Zel. Jelaqua just laughed.

“Don’t worry about me fighting in close quarters. I can handle myself.”

“Names, then.”

Halrac grunted. He eyed Xrn as the Antinium whispered and raised her staff. No lights flashed, but magic was done.

Slowly, the group walked over to the abyss. They spoke as they stood staring at each other.

“Klbkch the Slayer.”

“Jelaqua Ivirith.”

“Zel Shivertail.”

“Krshia Silverfang.”

“Halrac Everam.”

“Xrn the Small Queen.”

They leapt, and dropped slowly into the crevasse. Mage light bloomed around them, lighting up the rocky walls as they fell further down.

Lyonette watched them go. She prayed, although the gods were dead. She prayed to nothing and everything that Mrsha would be safe. Then she ran towards the city.

She heard the call echo in the darkness. Mrsha raised her head, nearly banging her head on the small alcove she was hiding in. Then she howled, as loudly as she could. She heard the answering howl, and then hid herself, curling up to hide from the bad things.

They found her an eternity later. Mrsha flinched when the face moved downwards, but the Drake only smiled wearily when he saw her.

“There you are. Come on, Mrsha. It’s alright.”

She was out of the alcove and in his arms in a second. Zel Shivertail held her as she cried wordlessly into his scales.

“Are you okay? Are you hurt?”

She was fine. Oh, Mrsha had bruised herself all over and cracked bones bouncing down, but she was alive. [Lesser Toughness] had saved her life.

They carried her out of that place. That was all Mrsha knew as she clung to Zel. They were all around her, strangers and friends. Halrac stood with his back to an Antinium whose staff glowed blue. He drew an arrow that glowed with the light of sunset and fired it into the distance. A *thump* and the roar of an explosion matched the lightning that thundered from her staff.

Jelaqua fought the shadows, flail whirling, striking as she created a deadly curtain of spinning spikes around her. Beside her, Klbkch was a dancing whirlwind of silver blades. Krshia loosed her own arrows, snarling.

And Zel? He carried her past a huge, red worm-like monstrosity. It was dead. It had been torn apart and he walked through the blood as the others fought. And then there was a rope, and a platform conjured out of magic. Zel stood on that, helping Krshia to haul the platform up as Xrn held it in place. Below, Klbkch, Halrac, and Jelaqua climbed rapidly, Halrac pausing to occasionally shoot at something below.

When they saw the light, Mrsha heard a scream. She felt Zel step onto the snow, and then Lyonette was hugging her. The girl crushed Mrsha to her chest, squeezing the breath out of the Gnoll. Hugging, kissing, scolding. Then the others came up and Lyonette prostrated herself before them.

“Oh, *thank you, thank you, thank you...*”

Mrsha stared up at the faces. Adventurers stood outside the rift in the snow, along with the Watch. Many people were gathered here. Some pointed to the abyss and screamed about danger. Others said it was a way in, a chance.

And many were mad at Mrsha. Some scolded her. Krshia boxed Mrsha’s ears as she checked to make sure the Gnoll was alright and called for another healing potion. And Lyonette was telling Mrsha she’d never, *ever* let her go out of her sight.

Selys arrived late with Olesm, almost out of her mind with worry. And some people recognized Zel and exclaimed. The strange blue Antinium left in the chaos, and Jelaqua stood alone except for when the others praised her. Lyonette told her to stay at the inn and Jelaqua just smiled. So did Halrac, awkwardly, as if it hurt.

And Mrsha? She looked around and saw many people, happy and sad. But no one was dead. No one.

Not even her.

Lyonette hugged Mrsha again, crying. Mrsha stared at her, and felt something break in her heart. But it wasn't a bad thing. The thing that broke was a wall, or maybe it was fear itself. She hugged Lyonette back and felt hot tears trickle into her fur. And Mrsha cried too. Because she was safe. She was finally home.

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Sometimes, in the silence of her own mind, Rags knew why her kind was so despised across the world. Privately, she could acknowledge the bitter truth.

Goblins were weak. They didn't level as much as other races—because they were cowards, too. They lived hand-to-mouth, eating their own dead, fighting each other over scraps. The strongest tribes were still forced to raid the more successful races to survive. Goblins were not creators; they only destroyed.

That was what she had been told. That was what she had known all her life; the contempt of other species. And Rags had believed it. But oh, if they could see what Goblins had wrought here. In this mountain, Goblkind had built something greater than their miserable existences. They had created something vast, something *new*.

A kingdom. Or perhaps, a new sort of tribe.

That was the only way Rags could think of it. She stared down from the balcony, down a mile to the bottom of the place the Great Goblin Chieftain had claimed as his own. Twisting corridors built into spires of rock that stretched upwards, countless bridges made of rope and stone, and always, always, the hanging lanterns, some unlit, others shedding faint light in the darkness. That was what she saw below her; a vast anarchy stretching downwards, like some strange spider's web.

She shivered, feeling a chill from respect as much as awe. Never had she ever seen something like this. This mountain had been hollowed out and made into a dwelling place for tens of thousands of Goblins. It had been built, under the leadership of Tremborag, or perhaps he had stolen it and claimed it as his own. Either way, it was a marvel.

And it was also a mystery. How could one tribe be so huge and yet, be ruled only by a Chieftain? This was the first of the things Rags pondered on her second day living in this mountain. Her tribe—and all the tribes around Liscor—had officially allied with Tremborag, and now lived in his home. There was plenty of room to spare.

But back to the Chieftain. Tremborag. He was only the sixth Goblin that Rags had ever known with a name. His tribe was known, fittingly, as the

Mountain City Tribe. But Rags had heard him more often referred to as the Great Chieftain's Tribe.

Great Chieftain. Rags frowned and spat over the edge of the balcony. She didn't know if she'd hit someone—no doubt she had. One of the dangers of living in this place was that a careless stone or object dropped from on high could turn into instant death for the Goblins moving about below.

How could it be? There was no such thing as a Great Chieftain, at least, as far as Rags knew. To be more precise, such an existence should have been impossible.

Some things all Goblins knew, even odd ones like Garen. You had your tribe, and you were lead by your Chieftain. But...there were other Goblins whose existence was greater than Chieftain. Rags could feel it.

A Goblin Lord was superior to a Chieftain. Their presence unified tribes, drawing Chieftains to them like a magnet. Unless you opposed one with all your might, Rags was sure any Goblin would end up following a Goblin Lord, even a powerful Chieftain.

And a Goblin King? Rags knew without a doubt that if one existed—and one did not, she was sure—every Goblin in the world would follow such a person. The desire for a King, a leader, was built into every Goblin deep down.

So it followed that all Chieftains would eventually become Goblin Lords, and into a Goblin King if they grew strong enough. It wasn't a choice they would make; it was just nature asserting itself, like how fire burned or how you had to poop after eating.

But then why had Tremborag not become a Goblin Lord? He could become one, Rags was sure. Like the Goblin Lord to the south, he had a tribe too vast for any Chieftain. Yet he was not a Lord. She would have felt it.

It made no sense. Like much in this place, really. Rags turned away from the balcony and walked down into a stone corridor. Two shadows walked after her.

Hobs. The Gold Stone Chieftain and a Hob from his tribe. They were Rags'...bodyguards.

Again, a foreign concept. But Rags had grown to understand that protection was necessary in this place. For while this tribe was Tremborag's, it was anything but peaceful.

There were...*factions* in this place. Not other tribes; Tremborag's had been the only one until Rags and the others had arrived. But the various sub-Chieftains who managed parts of the tribes or led their own bands of warriors fought with each other for influence.

Tremborag was in charge, but there were Hobs and normal Goblins below him who had huge amounts of control over other Goblins. It boggled Rags' mind to think of it that way, but it made a twisted kind of sense.

There was no way a Chieftain could manage tens of thousands of Goblins. But...if you assumed he was ruling over other, lesser, sub-Chieftains then it might work. It obviously worked. But it made no sense.

"Not Goblin."

Rags growled the words out loud. The Hob walking behind her flinched, but the bigger, fatter one, didn't. The Gold Stone Chieftain followed Rags silently, crunching down some rock salt as he walked. He was an odd Hob. He always had something to eat, and he rarely said a word. Actually, that wasn't uncommon for Goblins, but Rags had noticed the Gold Stone Chieftain's face rarely changed. He seemed unperturbed by anything.

But he was loyal. Rags was fairly certain of that, and grateful for it. It meant she had some power in this place.

Of course, Rags still ruled over her tribe. Only...where was her tribe? She recognized some of her Goblins scurrying down the corridors, carrying wood, helping butcher animal carcasses—or Goblin bodies. But they were scattered, already becoming absorbed into this place. In a very real sense, Rags no longer had a tribe, only her own small faction.

In some ways, Rags was the exact opposite of Ryoka and more like Erin. She didn't waste time wondering *how* all this had happened, she just dealt with the facts. She'd lost her tribe. Tremborag wasn't her ally and Garen was Garen. She was on her own and she had to find a way to survive in this new place.

As always. In fact, Rags took this new situation to be a challenge, and so dealt with it calmly and in true Goblin fashion. The first thing she did was go exploring, after making sure she wouldn't be stabbed in the back. The two Hobs helped in that regard.

The mountain was *vast*. From the outside it was obviously huge, but that was in a climbing sense. Inside, Rags couldn't help but feel she was in an entirely different world. There was so much space! Goblins had taken what was apparently an abandoned Dwarf city and slowly chipped away at

the rock walls and ceiling for decades, perhaps centuries, enlarging this place until it was larger than Esthelm or Celum. Perhaps larger than Liscor.

And like any city, there were places to sleep, places to eat, and places where going to the bathroom was acceptable and places where it was not, although it had to be said Goblins usually didn't pay attention to that last part. Rags already knew where her and a lot of the new Goblins' sleeping quarters were; they were higher up near the top.

She sensed this was another slight, or a sign of their weak position in Tremborag's tribe. Of course, normally higher meant better, but all the really good things like the exits, the main eating halls and the cooking places and forges were further down, which meant Goblins living near the top had further to go. Plus, it was more dangerous high up where you could fall thousands of feet before you went *splat* on the ground.

Rags didn't mind the height. She kept away from any place without railings or where she might slip. In short order she located another important place in the mountain, one that was again foreign to most Goblins.

The armory. Rags stared curiously at the four Hobs who stood guard around the doors. She understood vaguely what they were here for. But the presence of the armory itself baffled her.

She took a step towards the doors and the Hobs tensed. Rags raised her hands to show them she wasn't trying to get in. They relaxed, and a smaller Goblin came scurrying out, waving his arms frantically.

"Can't go in! Go away!"

He seemed to be in charge of managing the items inside. Rags pointed.

Why? Why needed?

He looked archly at her.

"For worthy Goblins."

Rags frowned at his disdain. She'd spoken in Goblin and he'd refused to use it. It seemed almost every Goblin in this place spoke the common tongue, however broken. Speaking in the actual Goblin tongue was looked down upon, it seemed.

And worthy Goblins? Rags supposed that fed into the idea of factions too. Any Goblin with Tremborag's favor—or a lot of influence—could get what they wanted. Anyone else had to fight for what was left over.

“What is in?”

The small Goblin—small compared to the Hobs, that was, he was still a bit taller than Rags—shrugged.

“Can look.”

The small Goblin meekly approached one of the Hobs. He snorted in irritation, but when he saw Rags and the two Hobs standing at her back he grudgingly opened the door for her to peek inside.

What Rags saw made her eyes widen. Racks of carefully placed swords hung in order of value, from high-quality steel to blades that looked like the metal had been forged by a true master of the craft.

Rags had never heard of Damascus steel, but if Ryoka had been here she would have recognized the superiority of some of the blades. Yet these were less important than the few arms that glowed or sparkled or shone in Rags’ vision as magical artifacts. There were few of these, but the swords were just one section of the armory.

Maces, axes, shields—a collection of bows and armor in all shapes and sizes! Rags saw a pile of books that had to be magical before the Hob shut the door. She stared at him, noting his superior armaments.

“Very good. Tremborag say, you take. Otherwise—not!”

The small Goblin ushered Rags back. She took a few steps and pointed towards the doors.

“Why not give to all Hobs?”

Why not distribute these weapons among all the warriors? Rags knew they could be of use; for every Hob she’d seen walking around with steel weaponry, she saw ten or twenty warriors with little more than sharpened sticks to fight with. If she equipped a force with what she’d seen inside they’d be many times more powerful.

“Only worthy Goblins. Only.”

“Makes no sense.”

Rags frowned at the Goblin, but he just shrugged and motioned her away. Reluctantly, she left. Did Tremborag fear Goblins would attack him if they had those weapons? Or was it just because he wanted to keep them fighting over such riches? Rags could understand that, but it still felt stupid to her. He was hurting his own tribe by keeping such treasures locked away!

No sense. Nonsense. It wasn’t the first time Rags had had that thought here. This mountain was so foreign, and Tremborag’s tribe so alien to her.

Some things made sense. Rags found the huge storage rooms filled with food, preserved by the cold temperatures, and magic runes in a few store rooms! She discovered areas devoted entirely to fletching, or where Goblins would hammer dents out of metal equipment, or clumsily craft things like the lanterns on poles. And of course the huge forge works and kitchens were equally impressive.

But always Rags was reminded that this place was not united. She saw some Goblins wearing ragged armbands, or tattooed with inks on certain parts of their body to differentiate themselves. All of the [Blacksmiths] seemed to be wearing a bracelet or necklace made of chain, for instance. Clearly they were in some faction that had a monopoly on manufactured arms.

And the divisions were clearer when Rags ate that night. She ate again with Tremborag and Garen at the head table—this time no one contested her seat, although she felt hostile glares which she easily ignored.

After a few minutes of eating, Rags glanced at Garen and Tremborag. Both had looked at her a few times, but neither had spoken to her directly. So she raised her voice above the din and spoke to both now.

“When fight Goblin Lord?”

Instantly, the length of the table—all those who had heard Rags—went still. All eyes turned to Tremborag. He looked down at Rags and grinned around a mouthful of bloody meat.

“Ah, you are impatient. Good. But foolish! I have told Garen Redfang this and I will tell you now: if the Goblin Lord comes here we will fight. Otherwise I will not move. It is easy to defend here.”

Rags saw other Goblins nodding at this, but she frowned. She understood the logic—this mountain was a natural stronghold that would take vast numbers of enemies to crack open. But Tremborag really intended to let the Goblin Lord gain strength while he hid here?

She looked at Garen. The Hob had shifted in his seat when Tremborag spoke, but he hadn’t openly opposed the Great Chieftain. Rags did, though. She grabbed some cheese and bit into it, chewing and speaking around her mouthful.

“Should go. Send army. I will go. As leader.”

It was a blatant challenge. Rags would gladly fight with an army against the Goblin Lord and level it Tremborag was too cowardly to. But he just laughed hugely, making his layers of fat vibrate and bounce.

“Ah, but who would follow you into battle? One or two Hobs? Your small tribe’s warriors?”

Tremborag pointed down the table at the Gold Stone Chieftain eating with the few Hobs and warriors loyal to Rags.

“The Goblin Lord would swat you like a bug, small Rags.”

He laughed and everyone at the table besides Garen laughed too. Rags bit her tongue. She had seen the bugs that lived around Liscor. Some were acid flies and they exploded when you swatted them. But she waited for Tremborag to finish laughing. He gestured at his hall full of Goblins.

“You can do nothing, not even with the legendary Garen Redfang. But I have an army as strong as the Goblin Lord’s. Stronger.”

She wasn’t sure if that was true. But Tremborag’s words had roused his warriors. They banged on the tables, shouting until he raised a hand. The Great Chieftain pointed at Rags, his voice booming.

“You want to fight the Goblin Lord? Well then. My warriors, my Hobs! Who would fight with Rags? Who would give her their warriors to command?”

Not a single one of the Goblins sitting at the high table moved. Rags didn’t blush; she just narrowed her eyes at Tremborag as he grinned toothily at her.

“You see? You have no power here.”

“I...*lead*. I am smart. I lead armies!”

She retorted. Tremborag laughed.

“You lead? Yes, you have [Tactician]. Garen said. Good. Then we shall see if you are as skilled as Redfang claims. Later.”

He waved a hand, and the conversation was done. Rags sat and pushed the rest of the cheese into her mouth, washing it down with some kind of pulpy juice, fuming. That was how it was, was it? Tremborag had just told her she had no power.

She was angry, but the rich food cheered Rags up. Clearly rank had its privileges here. Rags could look at the other Goblins in the huge throne room and see far less sumptuous food available to them. Indeed, some of the hungrier-looking Goblins glanced longingly at those eating at the high table. They had to make do with raw mushrooms, rats, and mass-produced soup that looked like the worst of the meals Rags had eaten when she was young.

Now that she was more able to take in her surroundings, Rags looked around and counted Hobs. Yes, a lot of them. Over a hundred. Perhaps hundreds of them walked Tremborag's halls, given that not all Goblins ate at the same time. It was a huge force, but again, a fractured one.

And most of the Hobs were young. As were most of the Goblins, in truth. In this place which was relatively safe, Goblins still didn't have long lifespans.

Then again...Rags had never seen an old Goblin, and she knew some, like the Gold Stone Chieftain, were over ten years old, which *was* old for a Goblin. But they looked like any other Hob—they didn't really show their age.

Except for one. Rags' attention was caught by a Goblin sitting in a corner of the room. He was seated not at a table but on the ground, a sign of his inferiority. But he—

He was *old*. Rags saw he actually had a beard. Some Goblins had hair, but she hadn't known Goblins could grow *beards*. But it was white and scraggly and dirty, and it kept getting into the bowl of soup he was eating with his bare hands.

She wrinkled her nose as she watched the old Goblin eat. He was messy, even by Goblin standards. He had a few teeth, but many were missing. He ate the scraps served to him greedily, laughing and chattering away with the filthy Goblins around him. For some reason, they all looked female.

Another...faction. She supposed only a very weak one would want a Goblin like him. But it was a sign that some Goblins could live for a long time in this place. Outside, elderly Goblins would simply fall behind or die to monsters or in battle as a matter of course. Again, not that Rags had ever seen one remotely as old as him.

At the table, the feast was still going on, but Rags wasn't hungry. She had a smaller belly than any of the other Goblins at the table. She was young. And small. And no one was paying attention to her. That was how she'd been relegated, Rags realized.

Tremborag and Garen kept their own council and talked to each other in private, and Rags apparently wasn't important enough to be included in any other discussions. Not that there was anything important happening since they weren't going to war yet.

The Great Chieftain and Garen seemed more interested in the little key he possessed. Rags could sense they had some pact of their own, although

neither one of them said anything. They just laughed and ate hugely, boasting of their abilities and achievements as they ate.

She had to admit, she didn't have the qualities to attract a following out of sheer might. Rags thought about this as she idly sipped more of her drink. She was smart and her tribe was strong, but that mattered little here it seemed. If only she was better with a sword or magic! She was learning both, but slowly. Meanwhile, the two sitting ahead of her were far more powerful than she was.

Garen was as strong as any Gold-rank adventurer, despite only possessing a magical sword and no armor or rings she could see. Mounted, he was a nightmare to fight thanks to his Skills, and it was clear that he was probably the most powerful Goblin in this place besides Tremborag himself.

As for the Great Goblin...he could probably just roll over and crush any adventurer he came across. Rags had no idea how strong he was, but she guessed that if she'd shot him with her black crossbow, the bolt wouldn't have gone through all his layers of fat.

After dinner, Rags went back to her quarters and sat, dismissing the Gold Stone Chieftain and Hob. She had to think. Here she was in a new environment, and she needed to gain influence. It wasn't about war and fighting any longer—it was about being respected.

She'd never had to worry about that in her tribe, even when she wasn't Chieftain. Rags stared at the stone ceiling, feeling odd. When she was just a Goblin, even if things were bad she was still a Goblin like anyone else. If they were running they all had a chance. There was only the Chieftain and the other Goblins. Other warriors didn't have more...*rights*. If they ate more food it was because they fought and needed the energy, not because they were special.

Rags had seen warriors eating scraps in that room along with normal laboring Goblins. It was all about power, here. Power, which divided a tribe against itself.

She didn't like it. But she didn't have to like it to use it to her advantage. Rags rolled over and slept, dreaming of ways she could gain influence in this mockery of a tribe.

The next day, Rags met the chief [Shaman] of Tremborag's tribe. Or rather, the [Shaman] found her. It was surprise visit, but when Rags saw the female Hob wearing paint on her mostly unclothed body and little else, she immediately made time for her.

She was very nearly naked. Rags had never met another Goblin shaman, so she had no idea if this was customary, but it didn't seem practical unless they all stayed indoors in the winter. Paint—some kind of chalky colored substance—decorated the female Hob's skin, creating exotic patterns that hypnotized the eye.

And other body parts, it seemed. For all the male Goblins the [Shaman] passed—and a good deal of the females—stared with acute interest at her, both at the parts seen and the parts hinted at.

Rags was young, so she didn't care. But she was suddenly acutely aware of how other Goblins cared about looks. The Gold Stone Chieftain grunted approvingly as he stared at the [Shaman]'s backside. Rags didn't see the point so she only scowled when the Goblins impeded their progress with appreciative ogling.

This was a type of power too, and the [Shaman] flaunted it. That made Rags a bit wary when the Shaman led her to her large and sumptuous quarters, making the two Hobs wait outside.

She had pillows, lots of them. And part of her room was clearly devoted to her craft; Rags saw a lot of items that wouldn't have looked unfamiliar on an [Alchemist]'s table. She gazed around in interest as the [Shaman] talked with her.

"You are Rags. A new Goblin and a Chieftain. So young!"

Rags nodded, meeting the other Goblin's gaze calmly. She had power too, Rags sensed.

"You had no Shaman in any of your tribes. Have you never met a Shaman before?"

"No."

She was very fluent, while Rags had to struggle to make herself understood. The [Shaman] smiled sadly.

"It is not good. Shamans make a tribe strong. Without us, there is only Chieftains and all they can do is hit things."

That made Rags smile. The [Shaman] whispered a word, and a ball of light floated from her hands, colors—red, white, green, black—blurring together in a light show. Rags stared at it appreciatively.

“We have power. We take it from the tribe. You know this?”

“Yes. Magic. Like this?”

Rags raised her hand and cast the [Light] spell. The [Shaman] gasped as an orb—perfectly mirroring the one she’d made—floated out of Rags’s palm. The Goblin smiled; she wasn’t so easily impressed by parlor tricks.

“You have magic. No one told me this.”

Which told Rags that she was being gossiped about. She shrugged.

“[Shaman] magic. Is like [Mage]?”

“Yes. And no. Different. My magics are basic, but strong with numbers. I can cast lightning and burn and create shields. And heal.”

“Heal?”

That attracted Rags’ interest. Pisces had taught her the fundamentals of magic and he had told her that healing spells were extremely advanced spells for mages.

The Shaman nodded.

“Close flesh. Restore blood. Not fix a missing arm, though. Still useful.”

“Very.”

Rags thought about how many healing potions she could save with a [Shaman]. She pointed to the female Hob.

“Only you? One Shaman?”

“I am Ulvama. Another five [Shamans] are in the tribe, but I am strongest by far. They can throw fire. I can scorch the earth.”

So you could have more than one if your tribe was big enough. Rags wondered if she could persuade a [Shaman] to join her tribe, or if Ulvama could teach someone. Could she learn?

“It is good that you think.”

Ulvama interrupted Rags’ thought. The [Shaman] leaned forwards and smiled at Rags, as if the two of them were sharing a secret.

“You are smart. And brave. I saw you challenging the Hob. But Tremborag does not think you are important.”

“No.”

Rags scowled. Ulvama smiled deeper.

“But I do. You need support. Allies. I can be your ally.”

Rags held still. She eyed Ulvama cautiously. A [Shaman], much less the chief [Shaman] of Tremborag’s tribe would be very useful. But why did

Ulvama want to help Rags? Did she really see something in her, as she was hinting?

Or did she do this to all Chieftains? Was she just playing the odds or did she want something? Rags didn't know, but she wasn't one to spit on an offered hand.

Unless it was someone she hated, like Relc.

"Ally is good."

"Yes. I can speak to other leaders for you. They are not certain if you should be followed or fought. But I can persuade them."

Rags was under no illusions as to how Ulvama would do that. She frowned; she'd had the birds and bees explained to her by Erin of all people, although she had no idea why birds would mate with bees. But would the offer of sex really persuade so many?

"Will work?"

Ulvama laughed.

"You are young so you do not know. But it will work, especially since you have a name. That makes you special."

Rags nodded proudly. A name was rare, even if the tribe had a [Shaman], she had learned. It was a mark of influence, and here, of power.

"One thing is strange, though. You have no Shaman but you have a name. Did you come from another tribe? Or did your Shaman die?"

Rags shook her head.

"No [Shaman]. Human gave it to me."

Ulvama's eyes widened. She stared at Rags, and then she shook her head sadly.

"Then it is not a proper name."

Rags stared at Ulvama, shocked. She hadn't *liked* the name Erin had given her, but it had stuck and she had long since taken it as her own. It was her name!

"Why not?"

"Only Shamans can give names. Not Humans."

Ulvama said it as if it were obvious. Rags didn't think this made sense and said so.

"My name."

"I can give you a better one."

"No. My name."

The two stared at each other, the good mood in the room evaporating like dew. After a moment, Ulvama looked away. She spoke more directly and with less smiles.

“You will need to gain support from other warriors. Find strong ones; make them your allies or make them yours.”

“How? Give things?”

Rags had an idea of how to gain power. Bribing followers, rewarding the faithful, demonstrating ability in combat and elsewhere—but Ulvama shook her head dismissively.

“Use that.”

To Rag’s surprise and outrage she reached out and poked Rags between the legs. The Goblin closed her legs instantly and glared at Ulvama.

“That is mine.”

She had no interest in sex, especially the way Erin described it. Goblins knew about the link between sex and babies of course; it was hard to miss the connection. But while Rags would have been considered a fine age for giving birth, she didn’t want to. It seemed like a pain.

“It is the best way for females. Do not be stupid.”

The Shaman was waspish. She stared at Rags and the Goblin glared back.

“Sleep with others. Garen Redfang if you can. He will help you for that—all do. Do not be—”

She was reaching for Rags’ legs. Rags slapped Ulvama’s hand down. The Shaman gasped in outrage. She raised a hand to strike Rags.

And Rags kicked her.

Kicking was better than a punch, mainly because people often watched your hands. Rags’ foot slammed into Ulvama’s stomach and the Goblin doubled over, coughing in pain. Rags sneered as she stood over Ulvama. The other Goblin was soft, lazy for all her power.

“No.”

When the Shaman looked up there was murder in her eyes. Rags stared down at Ulvama coldly, ready for a fight. She did not want to sleep with anyone, and she had no intention of being told what to do. Ulvama’s eyes blazed. She gathered magic to her in a wave, hissing with anger, ready to blast this upstart Chieftain.

But Rags had a hand on her sword and the [Firefly] spell burning in her hand. The [Shaman] looked at Rags and the smaller Goblin knew she was

wondering if she would be quick enough with her spells, or if Rags would stab her first.

“Get out.”

That was all Ulvama said. Rags nodded. She doubted the [Shaman] would be cowardly enough to strike her from behind. She walked towards the door. Then she turned at it.

“I need no name. I have one.”

The door slammed as Rags left.

Rags felt upset and annoyed for hours after meeting Ulvama. She'd been hoping so badly for help, and Ulvama had offered it! But not only had the Shaman denied her name, she'd tried to force Rags to do something she didn't want to, as if she had no choice. She was no true ally, and Rags had been right to not join up with her.

But however good it had felt to kick Ulvama, the consequences of Rags' actions were immediately obvious. When she received the summons to meet Tremborag with the other Goblins to plan a raid on a Human settlement, Rags found a room full of Goblin warriors standing around a map.

In this, Rags could find no fault. She stared appreciatively at the map of the local area and, of all things, crude figurines arranged around a town on the big stone table. It was a tool for planning attacks, and Rags saw Garen leaning over the table as Tremborag spoke with a Hob who was pushing pieces around.

When he saw Rags, though, Tremborag grinned at her. She saw other Goblins in the room turn to laugh at her as well and felt uneasy.

“Ah! Fake Name Goblin! Come.”

Rags froze mid-step towards the table. She stared at Tremborag. The Goblin laughed at her with his eyes and mouth. She glared at him.

“I am Rags.”

“That is not what Ulvama said. She said your name was given to you by a *Human*.”

So, this was the Shaman's revenge. Rags gritted her teeth, but she knew arguing was pointless. She pushed her way towards the table and stared at the pieces.

“Attack?”

“A raid. A Human town has many supplies and much food for the winter. I want it. But it is defended by many soldiers and some adventurers. See.”

He pointed to the map. All business now, Rags listened as another Goblin explained the rough layout of the town. It wasn't an easy place to attack by any means, she could tell. Stone walls, enchantments on the gates and even a tower spelled to hurl fire—add the Human defenders and she would have avoided it with her tribe.

But Tremborag had the forces to take the town, and he wanted what was within. He pointed towards the board where a self-satisfied Goblin had arranged the pieces in a rough circle around the city, their means of attack.

“What do you think, Fake Name Goblin? Garen says you are the best strategist. Can you come up with a better plan?”

In an instant she could. Rags took one look at the proposed formation and swept it aside. The Goblin made an outraged sound, but she knew his plan had been terrible. All he wanted to do was attack from every side, as if that would immediately overwhelm the stout defenses of the town.

In this, Tremborag's Goblins were equal to any other Tribe. Rags sneered as she moved the pieces around. In short order she had a plan of attack that had Garen nodding approvingly. Feint a heavy assault on the gates while other forces surrounded the city. Then—feint a second attack with lots of Hobs on the west wall while the east side saw Goblins snipe the defenders there and rush ladders up with the main strike force.

There were all kinds of other details of course, and Rags went through each phase of the plan. She paused when she came to the defenders, though.

“Adventurers in city?”

“A few. Not nearly as many as the soldiers, though.”

Tremborag grinned at her. He'd been watching her work in silence. Rags carefully added a few groups of Goblins and Hobs to suppress the small group of adventurers and stood back.

The other Goblins in the room stared at her plan of attack with grudging approval. Garen grinned openly and nudged Tremborag.

“You see?”

“I do. Well then, small Goblin. It seems you are capable of being a Chieftain after all.”

Rags bared her teeth at the backhanded compliment. He wasn't going to call her by her name ever again, was he?

Tremborag smiled as he stared around.

"Get ready for battle, my warriors! We will attack with many Goblins—and I will go as well."

This caused a stir among the Goblins in the room, and in moments all were volunteering to go with Tremborag. He chose only enough for the force Rags had proposed and then looked directly at her.

"And you will come too. After all, it is your plan."

She nodded. Rags felt a bit of excitement burning in her, along with guilt. She'd be killing Humans. But this was a chance to prove herself! She looked Tremborag in the eye and bared her teeth.

"Of course."

They mustered outside of the town just before evening. It wasn't far to go, hence Tremborag's desire to attack the town and the Goblins moved fast anyways. Rags found herself relegated to one of the side units, away from most of the fighting. She resented that, but comforted herself in the knowledge that this *was* her plan.

Rags stood in the snow, shivering a bit in the leather armor she was wearing—it was very cold—and staring around. A group of warriors, including Tremborag, had been gathered for the decisive actual attack on the eastern walls. They were hiding in a copse of trees. Garen Redfang would attack the western walls with some Hobs so he was not present.

In truth, neither Tremborag nor Garen were needed for this battle. Rags had gone over the plans; they had brought two Goblins for every one Human, and only some of the defenders could fight. It would be a slaughter either way; it only depended on how many Goblins their side lost in this battle.

To Rags' mild surprise, the group she was leading—one of the groups that would go into the city and tie up the Human soldiers—contained a spellcaster like herself. Only, the drooling Goblin who had to be prodded along by one of Tremborag's warriors was very unlike her.

For one thing, he had no ears. Someone had cut them off of him, leaving two earholes instead. Rags felt angry when she saw that; she knew some

adventurers earned money from Goblin ears. Maybe one of them had done it to this Goblin.

The Goblin stumbled towards Rags and stared at her blankly. She looked at him in disgust and turned to one of the warriors in her group.

“Why bring?”

The warrior shrugged as he examined his chipped sword.

“Stupid. Head is bad. But can cast spell.”

Rags stared at the drooling Goblin in doubt. He turned his head blankly towards her and grunted.

“Ah. Ugn.”

She wrinkled her nose and turned away. Ahead of her, Tremborag gave the signal and wild horn calls suddenly rent the air around her. The attack had begun.

The Human town had been peacefully going about its daily routine, safe in the knowledge that so many soldiers and adventurers were gathered here to guard it. But in moments a savage Goblin attack shattered their bubble of complacency. The soldiers on the walls shot down at the masses of Goblins with shields, doing little damage. Goblins swarmed all around, but the Human commander, whoever he was, quickly realized the main push was coming from the western walls.

Horns blew, men and women shouted orders, and the Goblins in the trees saw the bulk of the defenders go to fight off the Hobs that were assaulting the west side. Now was the time.

Standing in the back of the ranks of Goblins, Rags only heard the cut off screams as Goblins with high [Archer] levels shot the Humans on the walls and more Goblins rushed forwards with ladders. Tremborag shouted, and suddenly everyone was running.

Rags raced with her group to a ladder and climbed it nimbly. Above her a warrior choked as an arrow caught him in the chest; he fell and nearly knocked the dimwitted Goblin down with him. Rags cursed and had to pull the stupidly grinning Goblin up.

Then they were on the walls and in the main town itself. Rags ran with the warriors and two archers down one of the streets; they would stop any of the soldiers trying to help the others.

In less than a minute Rags saw the first soldiers breaking away from fighting at the gates and walls to fight the Goblins in the city. But they were

fragmented, caught off-guard. More of them rushed at the Goblins who'd braced themselves in the streets.

Goblin archers shot at the soldiers. So did Rags. She still had her black crossbow, and it killed one Human, sending him flying backwards and making the others raise their shields in alarm. But she didn't have time to reload it so Rags drew her sword and shield instead.

Before the diminished Human force could clash with the Goblins, the dimwitted Goblin was thrust forwards by the others. They shouted at him and he smiled and pointed towards the Human advance. Rags saw his hands light up—

And then bolts of electricity shot across the street, striking the Humans, making them cry out in agony. Rags was surprised, but the other Goblins had waited for this moment. After the stupid Goblin lowered his hands they rushed forwards, shouting.

Sparks of electricity crawled over the Humans in armor, making their arms weak as their muscles spasmed from the shocks. Rags shouted as she ran, and threw a [Firefly] spell at the Human in front of her. He screamed as the flying fire burned him, and then Rags cut his leg and slashed his chest.

It wasn't a clean kill. She cut him eight times, dodging backwards as he struck at her, screaming. But like the other Humans he was soon dead, overwhelmed by the Goblin's knowledge and superior tactics.

Satisfied, Rags and the other Goblins stepped back, some of them retrieving better quality weapons from the dead. She looked around. Two Goblins had taken injuries, one fairly bad, but none of them had died despite fighting so many Humans. True, they were strong warriors for Goblins, but this was *easy*.

Then Rags heard the shouts and felt the earth shaking. She turned and saw the adventurers.

There were only a handful of them, Tremborag had said. Only a handful. But when Rags saw the Goblins who went flying like leaves her heart caught in her chest. Somehow, in some way, the Goblins who had scouted this city had failed to mention one crucial fact, or perhaps Tremborag had failed to mention it to Rags.

These were *Gold*-rank adventurers, not Silver.

As Rags watched, a roaring man with a battleaxe swung, and the ranks of Goblins sent to hold him back went flying. They were like children before his strength, even the Hobs. At his side, a huge woman with a

hammer crushed a Hob's head, smashing right through the shield he'd held up to guard himself.

They were going to tear right through the Goblin forces in the city! Rags was paralyzed by indecision. They had to be slowed. But the Goblins with her couldn't manage it! They had to get to Garen, get him into the city with as many Hobs as possible—

Then she heard a *roar* which made the two Gold-rank adventurers freeze in fear. Rags turned.

And saw Tremborag.

At first, Rags didn't recognize the Goblin. That was because the Hob had changed entirely. A gargantuan creature, made of muscle and rage charged down the street. Eight feet tall, huge legs cracking the cobblestones as he ran at the adventurers—

It was the Great Chieftain of the Mountain. Yes, it was. Some of his features were the same. But all the fat had been changed to muscle, and he had become powerful, *quick*—

The warrior with the hammer raised it with a shout, but she was too slow. Tremborag caught her as he charged and smashed *into* a house. Rags flinched as wood and stone exploded like hail, and the warrior rushed in after his friend. She and the other Goblins heard shouting, then a scream. A female one. Then a man's choking voice—

In the localized sphere of silence, Tremborag walked out of the destroyed house. There was blood on his hands and around his mouth. The Goblins around Rags backed away as he walked towards her.

“How?”

That was all she said to the Goblin who stared down at her. Not a Hobgoblin, not a normal Goblin—something else. Some aspect of Goblin she had never heard of before. Tremborag smiled at Rags, and she saw the flesh caught in his teeth. His voice hadn't changed much, but it was rougher, harsher, as if speaking came harder to him in this form.

“There are more things in this world that you do not know than know, little Goblin. I am one of them.”

Then he turned and ran towards where the sound of battle was thickest. Rags stared at his back. She said not a word as the slow Goblin laughed and pointed at something.

Her knees were shaking.

When she saw Tremborag again, he was fat and normal, as if what she'd seen was an illusion. He stood, laughing and eating something amid his cheering warriors. They'd killed the last of the Humans and the rest had either fled or—

Rags still heard screaming, from female voices. She knew what was happening and it bothered her although she felt it shouldn't. But she was more concerned with Tremborag right now. She approached hesitantly.

"Ah! There you are."

He turned to her almost jovially as Garen Redfang joined them, covered in blood and lightly wounded, but steaming in the cold air with battle lust. Tremborag greeted Garen and then turned to Rags, smiling condescendingly down at her.

"Not bad, little Goblin. Not good either, though; you underestimated the adventurers. They are stronger than the ones you know."

She hadn't been *told* about them being Gold-rank! She should have assumed, but this had been a setup. Rags bit her tongue; she didn't feel able to talk back to Tremborag after what she'd witnessed.

The Great Goblin Chieftain stared down at her, musingly. He was in a good mood from the easy victory, and so he was magnanimous towards her.

"You are useful, as Garen said. You have my respect. Pick first and claim whatever you want before the others."

He waved his hand to indicate the city. Rags just nodded and turned away. She avoided the places where she heard Humans screaming and Goblins shouting in delight and searched among the dead, feeling wrong on different levels.

To her annoyance, anything remotely magical had already been claimed by Tremborag or one of his Hobs. Rags hunted about and found a wicked axe made of steel, a valuable weapon. But she didn't keep it for herself.

Instead, upon returning to the mountain with all their spoils, Rags searched for the Gold Stone Chieftain. He hadn't been included on the raid. But she gave the steel axe to the Gold Stone Chieftain, who immediately discarded the somewhat blunted iron axe he'd been using in favor of this one.

It was a good move, Rags knew. It showed the other Goblins she rewarded her followers, and that she wasn't greedy like others. She felt

proud of her decision—and immediately angry that she had to make it to fight for influence here. And she still felt a bit wrong.

Because of the Human women.

They'd been captured, over a hundred of them. Many civilians had fled or been killed, but some had been captured. The men had been killed, or so Rags believed. But the women—

They were somewhere in the mountain. Somewhere, being raped. That was what Rags knew, and she tried to not think about it too hard.

It wasn't her business. Some goblins did that. Garen's tribe didn't and she hadn't had to face the issue with her tribes yet, but—

She was too busy fighting for influence here to worry about Humans! Rags considered her new state of affairs as she grumpily ate food by herself. She had declined to go to the throne hall to feast; she was instead eating in a smaller room where Goblins could choose to take their meals.

The battle had been a victory, a huge success, it was true. But somehow, it wasn't *her* victory. Rags had planned the battle and it had gone well, and for that she sensed her value as a strategist had been established.

But Tremborag had altered perceptions by tricking her! Instead of a flawless battle, she'd been portrayed as stupid to forget the Gold-rank adventurers, lessening her worth. She had still gained from this, but—

Rags looked up as a Goblin stumbled into the room she was sitting in. No Goblin had chosen to eat here but her; they were all gorging themselves in the throne room with Tremborag. But someone had decided to eat here.

The dimwitted Goblin. He looked around vacantly, holding a bowl of soup in his hands. He spotted Rags and lurched towards her, smiling stupidly. Rags gritted her teeth, but she didn't kick him away as he sat near to her. He gulped his soup greedily, his eyes unfocused.

She tried to ignore him. Rags was still thinking about the Human women. She'd seen them, although she hadn't intended to, forced along at sword-point, some naked. A few had tried to kill themselves fighting rather than be taken, but they'd been overwhelmed and—

Not her business. Rags gritted her teeth. She stabbed angrily at the bloody meat on her plate. It was from a sheep and it was hot. She should eat it and find Ulvama. Maybe she could beat the stupid Shaman into—

“Flowing Water Chieftain. Will you speak with me?”

Rags *jerked* in surprise. She twisted, and saw the dimwitted Goblin without ears looking at her. Straight *at* her. And his eyes were no longer

unfocused. Her hand went to her sword, but the other Goblin hadn't moved to hurt her. She stared as the mindless, gibbering wreck suddenly sat up and stared at her with keen, piercing intelligence.

"You."

"I."

He agreed, smiling at her. Rags stared at him warily and slowly let go of her sword.

"Act."

"Yes."

They stared at each other. Rags' mind worked at the speed of light.

"Why pretend?"

"Hiding. I am [Spellcaster] to them. Weak. Stupid. But I am [Mage] to you. Stronger than I seem."

"Why speak to me?"

"Because you are different. I am taking risk. Would like to give you advice."

Rags paused. She stared at him and thought of the difference between his approach and Ulvama's. She nodded slowly.

"Tell."

"Do not sit with Tremborag tonight. Do not be proud. Be humble. Small."

Her eyes narrowed.

"Why?"

He smiled at her, exposing missing teeth.

"Is better that way. You are *too* smart, too quick. You may be threat, you foreign Chieftain. And if you are...Tremborag will crush his enemies with more than fists."

Rags considered this. It made sense. Tremborag was deliberately testing her, diminishing her worth. It might be a better move to pretend to be cowed by his displays of strength, although she hadn't considered it before. She narrowed her eyes at the other Goblin. And yet...

He was strong. If he was a better spellcaster than he pretended to be, he was on the level of any Hob in terms of value, perhaps more. He could be powerful. She pointed at him accusingly.

"Why you not fight? Why not stand proud? Why...*coward*?"

"I tried."

He tapped his ragged earholes and grinned at her. Rags paused. She stared at his ears.

Adventurers cut off Goblin ears. For that, *they* were monsters. But she had never heard of Goblins doing it to each other. Goblins killed one another as necessary. They did not mutilate. They did not torture.

But they did rape Humans.

She banished the thought. Rags stared at the Goblin [Mage] and nodded slowly.

“I will think. And not tell.”

“Good. Think hard, strange Chieftain.”

That was all he said. She and he went back to their meals. When they were done, Rags stood up.

The Goblin stared at her. His eyes were unfocused again and he grunted seemingly in surprise when she moved past him.

“Ugn.”

He stared at her vacantly. This time Rags was not fooled. She nodded to him and strode off, thinking hard.

That night, Rags didn't go to the high table. She instead ate with the Gold Stone Chieftain in a far more crowded part of the hall, as if she was cowed and humbled by her mistakes. She sensed countless eyes on her, but did and said little. She was thinking and watching instead.

Next to her, the Gold Stone Chieftain ate his food as stolidly as ever. He didn't react to Rags' presence; he'd just scooted over when she'd walked over without a word. Only one thing he'd done had surprised her that night.

When they'd been eating the Gold Stone Chieftain had stopped a passing Goblin. The old one. He was...or had been...a Hob, but he looked pathetic compared to all the others. But the Gold Stone Chieftain had called out to him nevertheless.

Old one. Sit.

And so Rags found herself sitting across from the old Goblin. He ate messily, burped loudly, and said little; he annoyed Rags more than anything else because he kept staring at her. So did all the other Goblins, to be fair.

She could tell that her absence from the high table had been noted. By everyone. Rags hoped the other Goblins just interpreted it as her being ashamed and going to her actual position in the hierarchy.

Meanwhile, the ranks of the Goblins were stabilizing as the new additions to Tremborag's tribe were assimilated. And it was his tribe, Rags realized. They were becoming his.

Already the Redfang warriors sat at the high table. A good number of them sat high up, bearing new scars from quick duels to assert their superiority. But as always Garen sat right next to Tremborag, clearly displaying his dominance.

She'd heard what had happened. Garen had killed another Hob, one of Tremborag's stronger followers in a quick fight. He already had his own band of followers, and Rags wondered if he'd picked a fight with the unfortunate Hob on purpose.

But that wasn't the only big news of the day. As Rags slept and woke, she heard the second big impact of yesterday's battle circulating through the mountain. Namely, the Human women who'd been captured.

They had been taken to a part of the mountain Rags had never visited. A dungeon-like place, where Goblins could come and go. Here too, access was restricted to those with favor. Normal Goblins couldn't enter, but more influential Goblins could access the women.

It bothered Rags more than she could say. But to her delight, it didn't bother just her.

While her tribe was somewhat ambivalent if not confused about taking Human women to have sex with, the reaction of Garen's tribe had been far stronger. They were *upset* about it, and Rags heard through the grapevine of Goblin rumors that a group of Hobs and warriors had gone to Garen to complain. Apparently, their tribe took pride in not 'sinking to that level', and they wanted Garen to stop it.

Perhaps he could have, but Garen was disinclined to go against Tremborag on this, especially because Rags knew some of the Human women had gone to the Great Goblin. So the message had come back to his tribe from Garen:

Deal with it.

The next night Rags didn't eat with the main host of Goblins. Instead, she waited until later. The Redfang Goblins had been given the important duty of guarding the mountain due to their combat prowess, but that meant they ate and slept at different times.

They were not happy that night and ate in sullen silence, or started fights among each other. Rags didn't say much—she just ate with some

Hobs and elite warriors who stared at her silently. She knew they were wondering why she was here, but she didn't do anything else. She just ate until one of them poked her softly in the side.

Redfang would not listen.

She looked at the one who'd spoken, a Goblin with a scar across his face.

"No."

He bared his teeth angrily and struck the table. The Hob sitting next to the warrior stared at Rags. He was a powerful warrior; they all were. Garen's tribe might not have been individually as mighty as he was, not close, but they were elites among Goblins.

Is not right.

Another Goblin said that. Rags nodded her head fractionally, and knew they were looking at her, gauging her reaction. But then the Hob who stared at Rags spoke.

"Gold Stone Chieftain. He goes to visit Humans often."

She paused. Rags' mind went blank. Often? Did that mean—had the Gold Stone Chieftain known about the Human women before now? They hadn't all been captured in the town. More were there from other villages, caravans raided, travelers abducted.

Often?

She stared at the Redfang warrior, and didn't know what to say in reply.

On the fourth day, Rags decided to join one of the raiding parties. Like the Goblin Lord—like any large tribe, really, Tremborag's tribe had to constantly scavenge and hunt for new food or risk starvation, especially with so many mouths to feed. Rags knew the Goblins grew mushrooms and harvested the native rat, bat, and bug populations, but that was hardly enough.

These raiding groups had the hardest jobs of any of the Goblins in Tremborag's tribe. They had to abandon the safety of the mountain to go

out and hunt monsters, animals, or raid Human settlements. It was...well, frankly, it was being a Goblin and Rags relished it.

She fell in with one of the lesser factions in the mountain. Curiously, it was a group of mostly female Goblins. They resented being seen as mates by every male Goblin who came along, and they were of the opinion they fought just as well as male warriors.

They did. If not with as much strength, then with a good deal of savage cunning. Rags participated in an attack on a Human village—no capturing women, just taking animals and food while the Goblins scared away the Humans. She had a chance to talk with one of their leaders, a Goblin who used two daggers dipped in a concoction made from poisonous plants.

“Faction is weak.”

The other Goblin looked at Rags angrily, but relented when she saw Rags was just stating the truth.

“Weak, but we are united.”

“Other Goblins do not treat females well?”

“Not as warriors.”

The female Goblin bared her teeth.

“We are strong as males. When we fight, we prove we are equal.”

Rags frowned. She didn’t think that was true. It seemed like this band of female warriors was being exploited by Tremborag and the other goblins to do dirty work with no real reward.

She said so. The female Goblin nearly drew a blade on Rags, but Rags had demonstrated that she knew how to fight, and so it didn’t come to that. The female Goblin wiped her daggers clean as she spoke harshly.

“Someday, many Hobs like us. Many.”

They wanted to become Hobs. Rags understood that. Being a Hob was power in itself, and if they had many in their faction they would be respected. But until then, they would live on scraps and fight the hardest battles. Rags shook her head.

Interestingly, she saw that the old Goblin was part of this band of female warriors. Rather, it was more like they tolerated him and gave him their protection. He actually fought, with a rusty greatsword that looked like it was more rust than sword. Rags wondered if he could keep up with the younger warriors.

But he had a lot of fighting prowess to make up for being older. Rags had seen him step on a Human’s foot, shove him down, and then kick the

Human unconscious without lifting his weapon. She supposed with age came experience. He grinned at her a few times as they returned to the mountain. She just stared at him and wondered what she was doing wrong.

She had to gain influence. Power. Rags became obsessed with it. On the night of the fourth day she paced back and forth in her room, wondering how to get a lead on all the other Goblins. Because, obviously she could do it.

She was smart, cunning, and Rags knew she was twice as competent as any of the other Hobs with their own faction. In a few weeks—a month perhaps—she would be able to amass as much power as the rest. And then...

It was all about finding the right allies. Rags had already decided who to approach first. So she summoned the Gold Stone Chieftain to her room after they had eaten dinner.

“Redfang Hob. One with mace.”

He nodded as Rags spoke to him in the privacy of her room. That was one of the most influential Hobs in Garen’s tribe, by far the strongest. The Gold Stone Chieftain stared at Rags impassively. She looked at him and remembered he visited the Human women. Often.

“Go. Be...nice to him. Gain trust.”

She would gain his trust and then take Garen’s tribe from him. Then she would attack more villages, gain more victories using only their force. With that influence she could—

“No, Chieftain.”

Rags halted, mid-thought. She turned and stared at the Gold Stone Chieftain.

“*What?*”

“No, Chieftain.”

“Why?”

She demanded it of him. The Gold Stone Chieftain pondered and then replied, looking at the ceiling.

“Not Goblin.”

That was an insult, one of the worst among Goblin kind. Rags recoiled and then became outraged.

“Obey! I am Chieftain!”

“Not if this is order.”

The Gold Stone Chieftain stared back at Rags, quietly defiant. It was too much. She could not lose him, her one supporter. Rags grabbed for her crossbow in fury.

“If you challenge—”

He moved *fast*. Rags had only been meaning to threaten, but the Gold Stone Chieftain moved towards her before she could raise the crossbow. She pulled the trigger and the crossbow bolt loosed—and missed. It shattered, against the stone next to his feet. The Gold Stone Chieftain grabbed the crossbow and tore it away from Rags, hurling it onto her bed.

Her sword. Rags had it but then it too was pulled away. The Gold Stone Chieftain hurled it aside and Rags stumbled back, suddenly afraid.

He loomed over her, huge. Rags suddenly realized how fragile she was, how weak. Without her weapons she was practically helpless. Her [Firefly] spell would only enrage him.

He visited Human women often.

But the Gold Stone Chieftain did not reach for her. Instead, he took one look at Rags and sat back down on the floor. He popped some rat jerky into his mouth and began to eat.

Stunned, Rags stared at him. The Gold Stone Chieftain spoke slowly to her.

“It is not Goblin. What you ask. Staying here is bad. If you stay, I will go. I will become Chieftain and leave. With my tribe.”

It was the most she’d ever heard him say. Rags stared at the Gold Stone Chieftain, stunned, and then absorbed what he’d said.

“*Leave?*”

He wanted her to leave? But this was the one place safe from the Goblin Lord! The Gold Stone Chieftain nodded, though.

“Bad place. Not Goblin. You said.”

He hurled the words back at Rags and she couldn’t respond to that. She could only come up with feeble excuses.

“Not strong enough. Need support. If wait...gain power. Influence—”

The words sounded hollow to her, weak. They didn’t sound like what a Goblin should say. She wasn’t speaking in Goblin. Rags met the Gold Stone Chieftain’s eyes and looked away, ashamed.

He stared down at her, disapprovingly. It didn’t look much different from his normal blank expression. But Rags realized—it was on purpose.

And slowly, sitting in that room, unable to meet the gaze of one of her subordinates, Rags understood. She put together the old Goblin, the Gold Stone Chieftain's knowledge of this place, and everything else together in a sudden conclusion.

"You. Lived here, in past?"

She stared at him. The Gold Stone Chieftain nodded. Sighed.

"Once. Long ago."

That was why he could speak the common language! But why had he left? And why did he want to leave now?

Rags could understand. She could understand the way this place made you do un-Goblin things and fight amongst yourselves, and how it took away tribes and the meaning of loyalty to the Chieftain. But was that enough to risk death fighting the Goblin Lord?

"Why?"

It was all she asked. And the Gold Stone Chieftain stared at Rags, weighing, judging. And then he stood up.

Follow.

It was a dark place where the Goblins held the Human women. A dark place, a former building in the Dwarven city. Dark.

And made darker by the crying. Rags thought there would be screams, but too many were broken by this place. She looked into rooms—for some reason the Goblins gave the Humans rooms, as if privacy mattered. She could hear well enough.

There were over two hundred women there. A large number. But for thousands, tens of thousands of Goblins—

Too many. And part of Rags stared at what went on here, at Goblins biting, grabbing, forcing—part of her tried to forget as she saw.

But she focused on one thing. She focused on the Gold Stone Chieftain. Because he visited the Human women often. He took one into a closed room with him, she flinching, afraid. Him impassive as always.

And so. This is what Rags saw. She saw the Gold Stone Chieftain let go of the Human woman. He walked over to one wall and sat down. And he pulled a carrot out and began to eat it.

He sat with his back to one wall. Just sat. The Gold Stone Chieftain chewed slowly as the Human woman stared at him. She stood far across the room, shaking. Then—slowly—she realized he was not going to do anything. While he sat here, she was safe.

Standing at the door, Rags saw how the woman lost her fear. She screamed at the Goblin, let out the rage and hurt. Then she retreated to a corner, wept. He sat and ate.

Visited often. He had fought for the privilege to be here, Rags had heard. Smashed another Hob into a wall. He had known this place existed because he had been here once.

And he had left.

Sitting with the Human woman weeping in the background, the Gold Stone Chieftain looked up at Rags.

“Too weak, Chieftain. Too weak. Too small. Still too small.”

He nodded to her once. Rags stared at him, and then the woman.

Then she went outside. Rags stared around. Her ears were keen and she heard every sound that went on in this place. Heard the begging, the cries—

And she wondered what she would have done if one of the captured women or girls was Erin. What if it was her?

And once that thought was had, Rags couldn't unthink it. She stared at a girl who stumbled back into her cell and saw Erin's face on hers. Rags turned away.

She covered her ears. She tried not to imagine how many women would have come here over the years, how long they would have lived. Rags told herself Humans did it to each other. She told herself that Goblins did it to survive, that it wasn't different than killing Humans.

But they all looked like Erin to her. The young, the old—they all had the girl's face. They were all—

She ran.

Factions. Infighting. Power struggles and politics, all hidden in the depths of this mountain. A place where Goblins were safe from all but each other. That was what Rags had found here.

But it was not her place. This was not a world meant for her. It was wrong. And she feared she was losing herself the longer she stayed here.

So Rags sat in her room and thought. She was a genius. She knew it, in the same way she knew the sun was hot and the snow was cold. There were things only she could do, only she could think of and dare to achieve.

So Rags thought about what she could do if she could not stay here. She thought, and the answer seemed so obvious. How had she missed it before? She had been trapped, that was why. If not physically, then in her mind. It had taken the Gold Stone Chieftain, taken memory and guilt and seeing this place for what it was to break its hold on her.

There was only one course. Only one thing to do. So when the Gold Stone Chieftain had finished sitting and eating, she summoned him back to her room.

It was late. In a few hours it would be dawn. Perhaps now was not the time—but Rags knew it had to be now. She told the Gold Stone Chieftain what she wanted and saw him smile. Just once, but she knew she was right.

“Can you—”

Rags paused. That was not what a Chieftain should say. She looked at the Gold Stone Chieftain and thought of the risks. That was her job. So when she looked him in the eye, Rags was certain.

“Do it.”

He nodded and smiled again, briefly. Rags let him go to find all the Hobs he knew that would listen to him, and walked out into the mountain.

She kicked awake Goblins she knew, and had some of them find the Goblin with no ears. Then she found the female Goblin and her band and kicked them too. Some she sent to find the Gold Stone Chieftain. The others she told to go eat with the Redfang Warriors who were having what was lunch for them in a smaller mess hall.

When she was done, she found the Gold Stone Chieftain again. She looked at him as he pulled out an onion and bit into it. The smell made her eyes water, but she was surprised when he broke some off and offered it to her.

“Ready?”

She asked him quietly as she chewed. He nodded. Grunted.

“Four Hobs. Not many.”

“And the other?”

“More Goblins. But all busy. Very easy. I can do myself.”

If he said so, she believed him. There was nothing more to do before the moment, then. Rags stared at him and asked a question that she’d always

wanted to know.

“Why name tribe Gold Stone?”

He shrugged, still chewing.

“I like gold. Gold that is not gold. I like it too.”

Rags knew what he was talking about. There were pretty stones that looked like gold you could find in caves with other minerals. It was valuable to Goblins, not just because it sparkled, but because it was a good alternative to flint and steel.

She looked at him, a silent giant. A Hobgoblin, a Chieftain who said little and sometimes did little, or so it seemed. But one with depth. One with a heart, who looked at what was and decided that it was wrong. Someone who wanted to be stronger but could do nothing.

“Why not you? Why not you...Chieftain?”

He looked at her, calmly.

“Not smart. Strong, but not smart. A good Chieftain is smart. Strong is easier, but not all are strong. Smart knows that. I am not smart.”

“You are.”

“Not enough. And cannot be Lord. Do not want to be. Like Tremborag. Too small.”

With that, he answered all of her questions and went back to eating. Rags stood beside him and then turned with a sudden impulse.

“Pyrite. I name you Pyrite.”

He stopped chewing and looked at her. Rags stared back. Pyrite was the name of such stones. It was a Human name.

“Not Shaman.”

“Do you care?”

She challenged him. The Hobgoblin thought about that for a second. And then he laughed. Pyrite smiled at Rags and nodded to her.

“See you later, Chieftain. Do not die.”

“I will meet you outside. You do not die. Chieftain’s orders.”

She left him behind. Rags made one trip to her room. She slung the black crossbow on her back, took her sword and shield, the buckler badly dented, but still hers. She had been given it by Erin. A Human.

And when Rags left her room, she was smiling. Because at last, she knew exactly what to do.

The Redfang warriors were disgruntled by the sudden influx of Goblins during their lunch shift. But they grumbled only a bit; they were more sullen than anything else. And they recognized a good deal of the Goblins who'd entered. They were part of the Flooded Water tribe and some of the other tribes the Redfang warriors had journeyed north with, so they were allies in a sense.

Still, the Redfang warriors were angry. Some of the Hobs in here were Tremborag's warriors and they longed to pick a fight with them. But they couldn't. They felt muzzled here, like the Carn Wolves who they had to tether in pens in the city and not allow to roam free. Their mounts howled in distress and the Redfang warriors were angry.

And then the double doors leading into the mess hall opened and a Goblin strode in, wearing leather armor. The Redfang tribe recognized her at once. She was Rags, and she...had...been their Chieftain. Not anymore, somehow.

But she was dressed for war. And it made all the Goblins who saw her sit up. Was something wrong?

Rags strode into the center of the room. Slowly, the eating around her stopped. She gazed around the room and saw Tremborag's Goblins, some of them. The ones she thought might respect her. She saw the Redfang tribe, sullen, angry, but wondering. She saw the Goblin with no ears sitting next to a group of Goblins who glowed with bits of magic. And the female unit of Goblins and the grinning old Goblin still eating happily in the silence.

The small Chieftain of the Flooded Water Tribe took a deep breath and then shouted. Not in the common language, but in the tongue that was hers. Goblin.

I am Rags! Chieftain!

Every Goblin paused when they heard this. They stared at Rags, thousands of eyes watching her. She stood proud. She stood taller than she ever had walking this place. As if she was ten feet tall. So she looked down at the other Goblins as she spoke.

I am Goblin. This place is not. If you are Goblin, follow me!

It was a declaration of war. Rags heard the susurrations go through the assembled Goblins as the damning accusation left her tongue. It could not be unsaid. Even now she knew the Gold Stone Chieftain was attacking, cutting down Goblins of Tremborag's tribe with the others she had sent him.

It was war.

"Traitor!"

A Goblin, one of Tremborag's, shouted that. He leapt to his feet, drawing his sword. But a bolt of lightning caught the Hob as he leapt for Rags. He fell, and Noears grinned as the Goblins seated around him drew their weapons.

And then the hall erupted into violence. Rags lifted her sword and fought. If she died here, she would die as she had lived.

A true Goblin.

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The mountain was silent when Garen found Tremborag. The Hobgoblin had to pass by patrols of warriors who moved in grim silence, weapons drawn and ready for a fight. But their attentiveness was in vain.

The battle was long over. It had been over before Garen had been awoken, and what he was seeing now was the aftermath.

Surprisingly few Goblin bodies lay in his path. Garen noted a few cut down here and there, usually in clumps—the losers of the rapid pitched battles in the night—but not many. True, some were being hauled away to be used as food even now, but it had been bloodless for what had occurred.

Rebellion. Or perhaps it was a choice, paid for in blood. When Garen saw Tremborag's face, he knew what the Great Goblin of the North would have called it.

Tremborag stood in front of two double doors, staring into a room Garen recognized. The armory. Approaching carefully, Garen saw the four Hobs at the doors were all dead. Two had been felled by blows with amazing strength. He suspected an axe. The other two were cut to death, probably from multiple blades all at once.

"They took everything of value."

That was what Tremborag said when Garen joined him. The Hobgoblin stared into the empty armory and nodded.

It was empty.

Oh, a few of the racks still held arms in them, but they weren't magical, only steel. Everything else had been looted, stripped away by the Goblins who'd fled the mountain.

Rags' tribe. And not just her tribe—

"How many?"

Tremborag shrugged, face blank as he stared into the armory. He kept looking at the empty racks, and Garen wondered how powerful some of the enchanted blades had been. Probably very.

"Two thousand. Four thousand? Six thousand? I did not count the non-warriors. But her tribe followed her, and much of yours, Redfang. And she took several hundred of my warriors and some of my Hobs with her."

"Mm. Bad."

Garen was no linguist, even though he spoke the common language. He saw Tremborag turn towards him.

“Is that all you have to say?”

The Hob nodded towards the armory.

“Took weapons. Anything else?”

“Food. Supplies. Most of your wolves—the ones who belonged to the warriors who left—and the women.”

That made Garen smile. Tremborag stared at him.

“You think it is funny? They are all *gone*, Redfang. One of the Hobs—one of the ones *you* brought here—killed all the Goblins there and let the women free.”

Garen Redfang just shrugged.

“Human females are not important. Less important than the arms.”

“Oh, but they’ve taken arms! And killed my Goblins! They have *rebelled* against me, Garen Redfang! For that they will die.”

Garen held back from pointing out that only a few had rebelled against Tremborag. Most had just followed Rags as she was their Chieftain. But Tremborag was looking back into his precious armory. His body was quivering with rage, and Garen watched with interest the way it made his fat wobble.

“Tell me, Redfang—”

And here Tremborag turned. Garen tensed as he saw the depths of fury that spilled from the Goblin’s crimson eyes. The Great Goblin seemed to grow larger in front of Garen. No—not seemed—his appearance took on the other form Rags had seen in the Human town. He stared down at Garen.

“Tell me. Give me one reason why I should not kill you now. You brought that little Goblin here, that *Rags*. Why shouldn’t I kill you since she has taken more than you have given me?”

It was a question that would lead to one of the two’s deaths if answered incorrectly. Garen grinned fiercely, grasping tightly the hilt of his sword.

“If you could. I have my fang.”

“Your magic sword does not scare me. Without your wolf to ride, you are slow. And your warriors have left you. Why should I not *kill* you?”

“Because I have the key. And I know where the other is.”

Tremborag paused. He stared down at Garen and the two locked eyes. Then Tremborag stood on his two feet, fat, angry, no longer the being he

had been before. Garen was disappointed to see that, but it was better than dying.

“You knew? Then why have you waited, Redfang? Tell me, and I will take it, no matter if it lies in the heart of Invril, behind one of the Walled Cities, or at the bottom of the sea.”

“It is in a worse place than that.”

Garen told Tremborag where the key was. He saw the Great Chieftain sigh.

“That is worse. Far worse. But I will take it all the same. As soon as I hunt down the small Goblin and eat her alive.”

It wasn't a threat. It was a quiet promise, and Garen knew that Tremborag meant every word. He said nothing. But he hoped that wherever Rags was, she was running far and fast. She could still be useful.

But what a waste. That was what Garen thought, and it was why he remained in the mountain. One kind of Goblin had left, the other stayed. Which group was right? Who was truly Goblin?

There was no one to care. The Goblins lived and died. The other races paid little attention to them, save for when the Goblins became a threat. No one remembered who the Goblins had once been.

Not even them. But some dreamed. Some looked back as the past called to them. But only the Kings knew the truth of it.

Death. Death and blood and sometimes fire. It was what followed her wherever she went. Rags accepted that fact. It was her nature, the nature of Goblins. She led the Goblins following her through the mountain, fighting any groups of warriors they came across. But the Goblins of Tremborag's tribe were lazy, secure in this place. The alarm hadn't even begun to spread as she met with Pyrite and the Goblins she'd sent to them.

Some carried magical weapons. Others, bundles of supplies. But the largest group was leading hundreds of Human women, most naked or wearing practically nothing. Rags shouted at Pyrite to find clothes now—not for decency's sake but because it was cold outside.

She began ordering the Goblins around her, taking command and organizing her Goblins, fighting for each second so they could flee before Tremborag's forces awoke and overwhelmed them. Then they were running,

dashing out into the snow as the Redfang warriors whooped and shouted, and their wolves howled, breaking a path through the snow—

When Rags woke up, her tribe was still on the move. This did not surprise her.

Goblins were perhaps unique among all the races of the world in that when they wanted to move, they could cover distances most armies could only dream of. Every Goblin learned to run away quick, and even if they weren't as fast as a horse or Human in the short term, they easily outdistanced everything in the long term.

How it worked was like this: if a tribe had a wagon and animals to ride or pull it, some would sleep on such vehicles, waking up to give other Goblins a turn. The animals had to rest occasionally of course; when they did they were normally eaten if the Goblins were in a real hurry. Otherwise, other Goblins would just push the wagons, sometimes with the horses crammed on top of it.

On foot it was different. Goblins would just collapse where they were and sleep, before waking and running to rejoin the tribe. That way they slowed their pursuers by offering free targets and a snack if the pursuers were monsters or other Goblins. Either way, the tribe would keep moving. They could cook, eat, pee, and do whatever they needed to do while marching.

And it worked well when it came to outrunning pursuers. So well that as Rags sat up in the crowded wagon, digging herself out from a pile of Goblin bodies, she saw the mountain was a good distance behind them.

How long had she slept? Probably at least six hours, Rags guessed. One of the benefits of being a Chieftain was that no one poked you awake and made you keep walking. It didn't stop other Goblins from lying on top of you and farting in your face, but no Chieftain could prevent that.

Stretching on top of the piled up Goblins, Rags yawned and ignored the grumbling under her. Someone tried to shove her leg off their face—she stomped and then climbed off the wagon.

The instant her feet touched snow, Rags realized it had snowed *again*. How annoying! But when she looked up she had to smile. Because it was a wonderful day.

The sky was very blue. Rags stared up into the winter morning, breathing in and smiling faintly as the sun rose overhead, warming her from

head to toe. It felt like it had been a very long season, full of cold and wet. But in a month or two it would be the shortest day of winter. And then the frost would end.

And a good thing too, because Rags had a tribe to lead. An even bigger one than before. Rags stared around. Goblins shambled past her, moving quick but all clearly on autopilot. She remembered what it was like, and considerately didn't disturb them except to get pointed towards food.

The Goblin approach to ingenuity was always effective, if not entirely sane. That was how Rags found a cooking pot bouncing along on top of a wagon, over a burning pile of wood *on top of the wagon*. In fairness, the Goblins hadn't set the actual wagon on fire, preferring to spread a layer of dirt to build a cooking fire on top of, but every now and then they had to put out fires caused by errant sparks.

All that meant was that Rags got a hot bowl of porridge seasoned with cinnamon, butter, and sugar of all things. She frowned, but ate three bowls greedily as befitted any Chieftain. Apparently, her Goblins had seized a lot of strange foods from Tremborag's stores in their mad bid to escape the mountain.

Sugar was a delicacy. One Rags had only really tried at Erin's inn. But it was also fairly useless to keep since it wasn't filling like grain or meat. Thus, Rags wholeheartedly approved of using it now.

Belly full, Rags turned to the next important thing on her agenda: finding out where the heck they were. She walked towards the head of the tribe of sleepy Goblins and soon found the Hob who'd taken charge while she was asleep.

Pyrite looked pretty much like he always did, albeit wounded. Several deep slashes had cut into his flesh—two around his belly, one on his arm. But none were too bad, and his fat had shielded his internal organs from harm. Even so, Rags resolved to find Pyrite a healing potion once they had sorted out their supplies. She'd always had an emergency stash in her old tribe's setup.

"Trouble?"

She asked Pyrite as she fell into step behind him. The Hob glanced at her and shook his head. He wasn't eating anything for once. Rather, he had a stick in his mouth. He was chewing on that and spitting out pieces of wood now and then. Rags supposed he liked to feel like he was eating even when he wasn't.

“No one follows yet.”

“Good.”

They still spoke in the common tongue. It was just...easier. Some ideas were expressible in that language whereas the Goblin's tongue always felt like it had holes in its vocabulary. But even in this language, body language, facial expressions, and context made up a lot of the conversation.

Rags turned to stare at the winding trail of Goblins following in their wake.

“Spread out.”

The Gold Stone Ch—Pyrite just shrugged. He took the stick out of his mouth and pointed with it to each side. Rags saw riders on the infamous rust-red wolves pacing alongside the Goblins. Scouts. She nodded, feeling reassured.

“Humans?”

That was the next issue on her mind. Rags assumed they were around somewhere. Again Pyrite pointed and she saw they were marching separately from the Goblins. She frowned; most were riding in wagons pulled by the animals the Goblins had liberated.

“Slow.”

They were keeping pace, but what she meant was that they were taking away resources her tribe could use. It was a criticism as well, but Pyrite just shrugged.

“Cannot survive alone. Must take. Too hurt to move, many.”

Rags glanced again at the Human women. She couldn't see much, bundled up as they were with whatever the Goblins had managed to take but—she believed him. She scowled, but made no further objections. She glanced at Pyrite. There was a lot she could have said. Thank you, for one thing. But Goblins didn't really do that. So she just nodded at him.

“Tired?”

He shrugged.

“Walking.”

She nodded. Hobs were tough, and he was fairly tough even for a Hob. She could respect that.

“You keep walking. I...think.”

He smiled, once.

“Yes, Chieftain.”

Rags grinned as he put the stick back in his mouth. He always knew what to say, even if it was nothing. She walked next to Pyrite, the two moving in silence. It was easy. Rags just let her feet take her forwards while her mind wandered.

What did she have to do now? Well, she'd established that there was no immediate danger, so she had to start planning for the non-immediate danger. That meant Tremborag's fury, the issue of them being exposed and in the wilderness where they might run into Humans, monsters, or something else, finding a new food source, a base, managing her new Goblin recruits, figuring out what to do with her tribe next...

Ah, it was good to be a Chieftain again! Rags smiled, even as she thought of all the things she had to do. It was hard work, yes, but she was certain that she could handle it. And if she couldn't, probably no other Goblin could. She was Chieftain, and part of being Chieftain was believing you were the best.

By her calculations, they had only one or two more hours at most before Tremborag's forces would be in hot pursuit of them, if they weren't already. The Great Chieftain might have a vast following, but it was slow to mobilize for the same reason. Getting together enough supplies and warriors would be tough, and they wouldn't be much faster than her tribe.

Then again, they didn't have to be. They would easily be able to follow Rags' tribe from the wake they'd left in the snow, and Goblin warriors could march longer than normal Goblins. It would come down to a battle sooner or later, and she had to find the best place for it.

Or did she? Rags frowned. What she really needed was a place to rest her tribe. Just for a little while. Her Goblins were used to rough travel, but the Human women were not. Plus, some of her warriors were injured and had to be exhausted after last night.

Last night. Rags remembered it clearly. She'd walked into the hall, afraid she'd be cut to pieces, that no one would follow her. She'd raised her sword and called for Goblins to follow her—

And they had. Oh, they had. Some had fought, but the majority had seen what Rags had. They had made a choice and chosen to be a tribe that lived and died free. They had chosen a Chieftain, rather than a faction under a Goblin who didn't care for their lives.

They had fought.

And they had won. From the mess hall, Rags had taken her Goblins, now a sizeable force and rampaged through the unguarded halls of Tremborag's mountain. That late at night they had been able to overwhelm what few soldiers were up. And such was the clamor of a Goblin mountain that the fighting hadn't actually woken that many. They'd grabbed food, tools, even fought their way to the place where the animals had been kept.

It had been a nightmare trying to get the Redfang warriors to control their wolves and prevent them from going on a rampage or eating the other animals. For that matter, trying to get a horse in the presence of wolves to behave was a bad idea. But Rags had done it. And then she'd linked up with Pyrite, who'd met her with hundreds of Human women and the loot from Tremborag's armory.

Rags had planned the entire thing. If she was going to break away from Tremborag, then she was going to do it in the most Goblin style possible. And that meant a raid. She'd sent Pyrite many of the warriors she was sure of, to help him free the captives and take weapons out of the armory. That was a prize too good to pass up.

Then they'd fled. They'd run into the snow, the mountain only now coming alive behind them. Some Goblins had tried to pursue them, but the Redfang warriors had covered their retreat. Out in the open they were ideally suited to engaging the enemy and retreating to join the others.

A victory. It was a great one, and now Rags just had to make it stick. And to that end...

She glanced at Pyrite. He was nearly down to the end of his stick. She watched, wondering what he would do when he'd chewed it to bits. Sure enough, the Hob spat the pieces into the snow as he passed. Then he reached into a bag at his side...

And pulled out another stick to chew. Rags gave up. She poked him and he looked down.

"Chieftain?"

"Who is...local? Who lives here?"

The language Humans and other species used was so much more precise, even if it wasn't theirs. Pyrite considered this and found a Goblin to poke. That Goblin wandered off and poked some other Goblins who all did the same...in a few minutes Rags had a Hob and two yawning Goblins in front of her.

She recognized them. One was the Goblin with no ears. Another was the leader of the female Goblin raiding party who'd joined Rags. And the last was the old Hobgoblin who grinned at Rags and the others, looking not the least bothered by their forced march.

"Chieftain."

The old Goblin said it first, bowing his head deeply to Rags. She saw Noears hesitate, then nod deferentially to her. The female Goblin hesitated, then copied Noears.

"Stop that. No bow."

She pointed to the old Goblin. She was not Tremborag, to demand such things. But a nod was appropriate. He straightened and grinned at her.

"Where place to rest?"

She looked at the three. The female Goblin was first to answer. She knew the landscape and told Rags of a nearby place that might be good. Rags nodded. She called out to Pyrite. He listened to the female Goblin's directions, found a messenger to poke, and in minutes the entire Goblin convoy was changing course.

It was easy. One Goblin poked another, both Goblins poked another, and so on and so forth. Within twelve pokes you generally had all the tribe's attention. And the Goblins at the front were the only ones who had to know which way to go, so if you had a halfway intelligent Hob up there, things ran smoothly.

Only the Human women failed to get the message. Some of them who were awake looked alarmed as the Goblins seemed to turn right as one. They stopped in their wagons, some pulling at the horse's reins to wake the others up. That was pointless in Rags' opinion, but then she saw some of the ones who looked like warriors were holding weapons under their blankets and clothing.

She frowned. Humans could be a problem. But to her surprise she saw Pyrite stump over to the Humans in the snow. They let him approach—some of the women clearly recognized him and others knew he'd freed them. It took Pyrite a few minutes, but the Humans followed the Goblins quickly enough when they realized what was going on.

And where had the Goblins gone? Their destination was already in sight, albeit camouflaged against the horizon. They were walking towards a hill.

The hill was just a hill. It was a nice workout for the legs to climb to the top, and it afforded a good view of the surrounding landscape, but that was all. The Goblins being Goblins, declined to bother to summit the hill and instead camped in the lee of it, sheltered from the wind. Rags still made a few Goblins go to the top to keep a lookout, but she was more interested in just letting everyone get a few hour's rest while she planned things out.

She had to figure out a way to deal with Tremborag's forces. This wasn't a good place for a stand, but Rags still wondered if she *had* to fight. She might lose a pitched battle even with the new weapons from his armory—especially since she had no idea how any of the magical ones worked. Obviously you could just use one as a weapon, but what if its magical effect was emitting an aura of flame, or creating some kind of special effect? One wrong swing and you'd fry your side.

How could she get rid of Tremborag's retaliation force? Rags went through all the Goblin fallbacks. Fighting was no good, she couldn't outrun them, she doubted she could hide their tracks or her tribe...bribing wasn't going to work. Surrender meant death. But what if she—

“Chieftain.”

Rags looked up with a scowl as she sat in a patch of cleared dirt. Who was bothering her? She saw six Goblins waiting for her and immediately sat straighter.

These weren't any ordinary Goblins. If the tribe Rags had led out of the mountain had factions—and if it did she'd get rid of them soon enough—these were it. More accurately, they were the factions from the mountain.

Six Goblins. Rags saw Pyrite, looking impassive as ever, Noears, the female Goblin leader, and the old Goblin. But two other Goblins had joined them.

One was a Hob that Rags recognized. He was – had been one of Tremborag's warriors who sat at the high table. He was a good warrior as far as she knew, but not outstanding. He was at the bottom of the rung since he didn't have a huge faction behind him, and she suspected he had joined her simply because he didn't want to have to fight for influence with the others Hobs. He probably represented the Hobs who'd lived in the mountain.

The other warrior was a normal-sized Goblin with a scar over his face. He was one of the elite Redfang warriors and Rags had already privately dubbed him Redscar. Of all the Goblins present, she was only really

concerned about his faction. The others were smaller or behind her all the way like Pyrite. But the Redfang warriors were an independent lot and she didn't know if they trusted her or she could trust them.

Rags stood. The Goblins waited for her to speak. She nodded, and then spoke in their tongue.

I am Chieftain.

It needed to be said. The other Goblins nodded, the mountain Hob and Redscar slowest of the lot. Rags noted this, and went on.

This tribe is Goblin.

Another easy statement, and all the nods were quick this time. This tribe was Goblin. They'd fought for it. Only Rags' leadership was disputed. She thought about this, and then pointed in a random direction.

"If you not like...go over there."

All the Goblins turned and looked. Rags shook her head.

"Not there. Go away."

It was an unusual statement. Normally Goblins didn't abandon their tribes no matter what. If they had an issue they challenged the Chieftain or left with as many Goblins as they could gather to form a new tribe. However, since this was in itself a challenge the breakaway Goblins usually had to fight to leave their tribe. But Rags was telling the others to just go if they had their differences.

All the Goblins present considered this. Rags looked from face to face, frowning when she saw the old Goblin. Why was he even here? But maybe Pyrite had brought him. He seemed to know the old one. And after meeting Noears, Rags realized some Goblins were hiding their true natures.

Noears. There was another thing to think about. Rags knew nothing about him other than that he could cast powerful spells and he had once been targeted by Tremborag. Was he loyal?

Time would tell. Rags pointed to Pyrite.

"He is big Hob. He tell my orders."

Pyrite looked vaguely surprised, but the other Goblins looked willing to accept this, even Redscar. Every Chieftain needed a few Hobs who were competent enough to follow orders. Pyrite was the best choice.

That done, Rags waited for the other Goblins to speak. Something had brought them here. At last, the mountain Hob spoke.

“Chieftain. Will we fight Tremborag’s forces?”

He had the same clear diction of the other Goblins from Tremborag’s tribe. It was too Human-sounding for Rags’ taste. She scowled.

“Hope not.”

“Chieftain. Where are we going?”

“Away.”

“What will we be doing?”

“Goblin thing.”

This answer clearly didn’t please the Goblins who’d lived in Tremborag’s tribe. But what did he expect? Pyrite just smiled and the old Goblin cackled. Even Redscar grinned.

“This is how Goblins act. She is true Goblin, Goblin Chieftain Rags!”

The old Goblin slapped the younger Hob on the back. He turned and glared, but Rags just nodded.

“I am Chieftain. I decide. You go. I think!”

This was how Goblins worked. The Chieftain made decisions—sometimes at random, and the tribe adapted. Some Chieftains were better than others—Rags knew Garen was famous for his split-second decisions which forced his Hobs to scramble to keep up. But she would have a plan. A good one.

If only she could figure out what it was.

While she waited for one to appear, Rags took a circuit of the camp. The stolen weapons were piled in a wagon, not touched by any Goblins yet although she saw some warriors eying them. But they were smart enough to realize that they would probably get weapons in the end and that stealing them would earn a thumping from one of the Hobs who had an eye on the wagon.

Next? Cooking. Rags found a brunch being cooked up from one of the horses who’d broken an ankle in the snow. She regretted losing such a valuable animal, but it did taste good.

And last? Rags went to see the Human women.

They’d entrenched themselves a ways away from the Goblins. They were a bit pathetic, in Rags’ opinion. They huddled together, sitting at one of the fires that the Goblins had had to build for them. And they didn’t want

any Goblins coming near them, especially not any males. The only ones who could approach were female Goblins with food...or Pyrite.

Rags approached them now. She saw one of them—a Human adventurer by the looks of her—holding her sword, but she didn't flinch. She walked up to her, as she seemed to be the one in charge.

She was battered. She must have been captured in the attack on the town. Rags had no idea if the woman was a Gold-rank adventurer, but she'd been attacked by the Goblin warriors who'd hit her repeatedly. She was still recovering, although Rags thought some Hob might have given her a potion for her injuries.

The woman stared at her warily with the rest of the women. Rags stopped in front of the adventurer and held out her bare hands. The woman saw Rags was unarmed and released the grip on her sword hilt.

“Mm. Understand me?”

All the Humans jumped. Rags rolled her eyes. How could they not know Goblins could speak? The adventurer stared at her.

“I...do. Who are you?”

Her voice was hoarse and she had to cough as she spoke. Rags pointed at her chest.

“Chieftain.”

Another incredulous look. They stared at Rags, and then at Pyrite, sitting and eating fried horse meat by a fire. The Goblin sighed again. Humans. Did they think biggest was always best?

She gestured to the camp, speaking slowly so they could understand.

“Not harm. No harm. Follow. Eat. Live.”

“Why?”

The adventurer stared at Rags, wanting to hope, but not quite daring to. Rags smiled. She tapped her chest.

“I am Goblin. True Goblin.”

They stared at her as if they didn't understand, but Rags was used to that. She'd dealt with Erin more than enough times. She stood up and left. So long as they didn't cause trouble, that was fine.

Human women. After meeting them Rags was decided. She had to ditch them as soon as possible. She was aware of what they'd gone through and even sympathetic—saving them had been the right move. But they were slow, suspicious, and they ate food Rags' tribe would need. In short, they were fairly useless to Goblins.

But they would be useful because they were Humans. And Rags' tribe hadn't harmed them. In fact, they'd rescued them. The beginnings of an idea stole into the young Goblin's mind and she smiled.

It was time for a daring plan. She went to Pyrite. He was sleeping. So Rags found Noears instead. He was busy eating and chattering to another Goblin with a band of feathers tied to a staff. Another magic-user? Rags would investigate later. She pointed at Noears.

"Where Human cities?"

He stood up and showed her. It turned out that Noears had taken a detour from the others when fleeing the mountain. He hadn't gone for supplies or anything else—instead, he'd gone to the war room where the Goblins planned their attacks and stolen all the maps. Rags cackled with glee as he spread them out on a wagon.

"Here, here, and here, Chieftain."

The map was the first real picture Rags had ever seen of the continent. She stared avidly at it, noting how the Human cities were all dispersed a good distance away from each other—except in the north, where they were quite clustered in some places. There were far less cities the closer they came to the High Passes, indicative no doubt of how far the Humans had settled.

There were several cities close to them. Rags looked at Noears. He was watching her intently, gauging her, she guessed.

"Most dangerous?"

He thought and pointed. Rags looked at the cities nearest to their position, shaking her head at some, nodding at others.

"What kind of death?"

That was a very Goblin question. Noears answered it in a very Human way.

"[Knights] and [Riders], Chieftain. Very fast. They run down Goblins with lances. Strong mages, but not many leave walls. Cities have armies. Riding patrols are common."

Rags frowned. That was a lot more than she'd grown accustomed to around Liscor. Patrols were regularly sent from the city, but only to weed out monsters. They didn't have mobile forces.

Still, if her idea worked they wouldn't need to fight any Humans. And if they did...Rags patted at her pouch. She still had the gem of [Terror]. She

hadn't had much call to use it against Goblins—it was ineffective—but it could give the Humans a good scare.

“Good. We move soon! Go tell others!”

She gave Noears the task of poking the others awake and getting the tribe moving. It was time to put her idea into action. They headed straight for the nearest Human city, a few hour's march away. It was going to be a dangerous plan, but almost all Goblin plans were dangerous.

Behind her, a vast army of Goblins was no doubt on its way to kill Rags and her tribe. Well, so what? She sneered at Tremborag's might. He could kill Gold-rank adventurers in seconds...which was really scary and impressive. But she didn't need lots of muscles. She was going to beat all his elite warriors with her head.

The Human city was named Merendia, or perhaps Balum. Or was it Ostegrast? Rags didn't know, and she was annoyed by the way the other Goblins from Tremborag's tribe argued about it. Who cared what it was called? It was a Human city. That was all the context you needed.

And it had a lot of Humans in it. And high walls. And as Rags stared up at it, she couldn't help but notice all the Humans with bows who shouted and raised the alarm as they saw the Goblin tribe appearing out of the plains and marching towards them.

They thought it was an attack. And even as Rags watched, a mounted force rode out of the gates. Men and women in armor, armed with the long lances she'd heard of but never seen in person. A mobile force, quite unlike the forces Drakes employed. They didn't get along as well with horses.

It was a formidable force, even without the adventurers Rags spotted on the walls, practically aglow with magic. More than one Goblin in Rags' tribe gulped, especially the ones who weren't actually warriors. But Rags ordered them to move forwards without fear.

In the ordinary way of things Rags guessed the Humans would have let them approach while they blasted them with spells and rained arrows on their heads. The cavalry would hit the tribe from the flanks and the adventurers would kill scores of Goblins and all the Hobs themselves.

It would be a massacre. If Rags were stupid enough to attack the city. Which she wasn't.

She laughed with delight as the Humans stared at her tribe crossing the main road leading out of the city. Why did the Goblin army cross the road? Quite literally to get to the other side. But why hadn't they done that away from the city? Already the Humans were reconsidering their approach. The mounted force was circling Rags' tribe at a distance. They weren't about to let this many Goblins get away where they could attack smaller villages or settlements.

A [Mage] on the walls was getting ready for a big spell, Rags could tell. She tensed, wondering if the Humans hadn't seen yet. She didn't want her tribe to lose any Goblins today—

A cry went up from the mounted force as they circled Rags' marching Goblins. A cluster of them raced towards the town, their riders standing up in their stirrups and shouting at the Humans on the walls. In Rags' vision the [Mage] stopped casting the spell and she sighed in relief.

Why did the Humans not attack this tribe? The answer was simple. From their perspective, the Goblins had hostages.

Hundreds of Human women, no doubt captives of the Goblins, made to do unspeakable things. That was broadly true, and Rags did consider the Humans as valuable shields. But not a shield in the sense of having hostages.

The Humans had stirred when seeing the city. They'd begun to look hopeful, but as they'd seen the army pouring out of the gates, they'd begun staring at the Goblins, wondering if they were going to be held captive. Rags saw the female adventurer leading them looking at the Goblins and at the cavalry, clearly wondering if she and her friends could make a break for it.

That was why Rags had positioned her tribe so they were in front of the Humans in the city. She rode towards the women on her Carn Wolf as they halted in place. They stared at her in fear and the adventurer gripped her sword.

"Goblin. We wish to go to that city. Do you understand? If you let us go, we will promise not to attack your tribe."

The woman called out to Rags, looking from her to the walls again. Rags stared down at her, and then nodded genially.

"Good. Do."

The adventurer's head turned back towards Rags and her face went slack as if she couldn't quite believe what she'd heard. She clearly hadn't

expected Rags to agree that easily. She looked at Rags.

“Do you want...money? Food? A ransom?”

“No. Go. But off wagons.”

Rags had no intention of letting the Human women keep the horses or the wagons. She made gentle shoing gestures even as the adventurer stared at her.

“Go, go. No need for Humans. Too slow. Eat too much. Also ugly. Go, go.”

Half the women stirred at that, but Rags just kept waving her hands, repeating her gestures. The adventurer stared at Rags, but after a moment she seemed to realize that the Goblin was being genuine, even if the reasons escaped her.

What must the Humans on the walls of the city think, to see the Human captives dismounting and slowly forming a group which marched towards them, away from the evil Goblin tribe? Rags had no idea. But she had her tribe march double-time, crossing the road and moving further into the wilderness.

It was purely a diversionary tactic. Distracted by the Humans, the city was only too willing to avoid a fight. As soon as a good bit of distance had been put between the tribe and the women, the cavalry immediately closed in. They formed a wall between the tribe and the captives, which handily let Rags’ tribe go on its merry way. The Humans on the walls were shouting, rushing about, no doubt preparing to receive these women.

But another cry went up when they saw the lone Goblin turn from the already distant tribe of Goblins and ride towards the women. Humans gripped their bows, but they didn’t fire. Because, of course, this was one lone Goblin, hardly a threat even if she was riding a Carn Wolf. And the Humans were gripped by a trait of their species, which was curiosity.

Rags rode back towards the Human women, ignoring the mounted warriors who spread out, encircling her. They might have tried to pull her off her mount—in which case Rags had the gem of [Terror] clutched in one sweaty hand ready to use—but the adventurer called out and stopped them.

“See? Humans go.”

That was what the Goblin said as she pulled her Carn Wolf to a stop a few paces away from the Human woman. The wolf *huffed* and sniffed at the adventurer, but she looked up at Rags without fear.

“You let us go. And the other Goblin—he liberated us in that mountain. Why?”

“True Goblins.”

Rags said it again and this time the adventurer seemed to understand. She hesitated, and then bowed her head.

“We owe you a debt. But you are Goblins...”

In short, still scum to be exterminated from the face of the earth. Rags nodded, still genial. Then she pointed at the Human adventurer, at her bruised face.

“Bad Goblin did this. Bad Goblin.”

The woman stiffened. Then she nodded. Hatred burned in her eyes.

“Yes. He lives in the mountain. I will remember his face.”

Rags pointed the way they’d come.

“Mountain Goblins. Yes. Big tribe. Big leader. Great Chieftain. Tremborag.”

The woman started.

“*Tremborag*? A Goblin with a name?”

“Yes.”

Rags nodded energetically. She waved her arms to show the other Humans—warrior types who’d drawn closer out of curiosity and their squad’s leader, who looked fiercely interested in what she was saying.

“Tremborag. Very scary. Strong. Fought in Goblin war. With Goblin King.”

A susurrantion went through the Humans. Rags liked that word. Susurrantion. It was a word that meant gasping and muttering and meaningful looks to one another. The adventurer looked pale.

“Thank you for telling me this. He will be...we will do what is necessary.”

They’d make a big army and attack him. But Rags wasn’t done. She pointed in the direction of the mountain, visible in the distance.

“Mountain. Great Chieftain.”

“Yes?”

The woman frowned, clearly wondering why Rags was repeating herself. Rags grinned and pointed south.

“Goblin Lord.”

Another gasp, but this time there was less surprise. Rags saw the Human woman frowning, and then reaching a conclusion.

“They’re...going to join forces?”

Close enough. The look on the other Human’s faces was priceless. Rags nodded, pretending to look concerned. Then she waved at Human.

“Goodbye.”

“What? Oh—you’re going?”

Rags nodded. She eyed the riders. They clearly weren’t sure if they should let her go. Honor was one thing, but she was a Goblin after all. The adventurer looked from Rags to the mounted warriors and called out.

“Please, let her go. She rescued us. I don’t think she’s...hostile.”

“But Miss—”

“You heard her. I’ll make an exception. I take full responsibility for this decision. Part ranks!”

Their leader called out. The riders moved aside and Rags nodded to the adventurer. The woman stared at Rags, searching her eyes.

“Before you go—who are you? Do you have a name?”

Rags paused. She turned as she guided her Carn Wolf around and grinned at the woman. She pointed at herself.

“Rags. Chieftain of the Flooded Waters tribe.”

Then she kicked her wolf and after he glared at her, he shot away. She left the city behind as the gates opened and the Humans rushed out, demanding to know what had happened. Much was happening back there, much drama and crying and confused explanations no doubt. But that was the Human’s problem. Rags had done what she came for.

She caught up to her tribe a few miles past the city. They were still marching, headed towards a forest on the map. It looked like it had a lake nearby, which would be good for water and fish. There might be monsters, but it was a good place to set up for a few days.

And they had a few days! Rags rode her wolf through the ranks of Goblins. As she did, a huge cheer went up that made the wolf snort in surprise. But the Goblins understood.

Rags had done it! Without a single shot loosed, without a single Goblin dead, she’d managed to lose whatever force Tremborag had sent after them. Tremborag’s Goblins might be fierce, but even they’d hesitate to go right past a city. A battle would be inevitable, and even if they overcame the city’s walls and defenders—and they might—it would be costly and attract too much attention from the Humans.

For that matter, now that Rags had let the Human women go, there would be serious repercussions for Tremborag anyways. His mountain was exposed; the Humans had seen the inside, seen how many Goblins there were. And if they thought he was going to help the Goblin Lord—a Great Chieftain of the Goblins who’d fought with the Goblin King? What could be more dangerous? They’d send out a force to attack him right away.

He’d probably survive. But in the meantime Rags would be free. So she sat on her wolf’s back and laughed and laughed in the cold air. If there was anything Goblins liked to do, it was gloat since they seldom had a chance to try it.

“Time to make tribe better.”

That was what she said to Pyrite as she rode up beside him and hopped off to walk. Her crotch and butt hurt when she rode the wolf for too long. He nodded at her, smiling faintly as he crunched on something. Rags stared at him.

“Rocks?”

Pyrite spat the bits of stone out and shrugged.

“Tastes like rock.”

“Why?”

“Keeps teeth sharp.”

That was true enough. And it wasn’t like he was in danger of losing any; Goblin teeth fell out and regrew anyways. Rags shrugged.

“Forest. We organize properly.”

He nodded.

“Good.”

“And get healing potion. For you.”

He shrugged.

There was a reason why Rags was a Chieftain so young. There was a reason why even Garen Redfang needed her. True, part of that reason was very confusing and involved a girl named Erin Solstice, but mostly it was due to Rags being smart.

Everyone knew this was true. Rags was a genius. If they knew the word for prodigy, the Goblins might have referred to her as one. But they didn’t, so she was just smart.

Very smart, as it turned out. As soon as the Flooded Waters tribe arrived at their destination, Rags began organizing the tribe, much to the surprise of Tremborag's former Goblins.

Normally a tribe just let any Goblin do what needed doing. Hobs rounded up Goblins who were close to them for tasks, without any particular rhyme or reason unless the Goblin was known to be good at that particular task. But Rags disapproved of such inefficiencies. She craved order, so she created it.

Division of labor. Rags already had the practice of dividing Goblins by skills, but now she formed multiple groups that would work in the day and night. Like the warriors. They were by nature fairly lazy when not fighting in order to conserve strength, but Rags put them on rotating patrols, day and night shifts, and assigned them to groups she could call upon on demand.

It was very complicated, but only for the one in charge. The individual Goblins only had to look up to one particular leader and hang out with one group, so it was simple and easy for them. Rags immediately set about fortifying this location, spreading out her camp so that the warriors had places around the outside while the largest camp was in the inside. She ordered the Redfang warriors to scout the area while she had another group of Goblins check out the lake.

When the warriors reported that the most dangerous creatures living nearby was a few Mothbears, quite able to kill any other intruders into their domain, Rags sent a group of warriors to hunt the bears while she sent foraging teams in every direction. While she did that, she pondered what to do with the mages.

There were four of them, including Noears. They weren't really warriors in the sense that Rags wanted them on patrol, but they had useful abilities. Some could start fires. Noears was good at shooting lightning, but all the [Mages] wanted was to practice magic and eat. Rags eventually decided to attach them to warrior groups, which went over pretty well.

The Redfang warriors were delighted to have something to fight. They came back with only a few wounds and six Mothbears ready to be skinned and eaten. Rags had already decided they were going to be a core of her fighting force...

If she could figure out what that fighting force would be.

Here was the problem. Rags sat in the middle of her camp where all her Goblins were busily cooking, eating, sleeping, or doing all the important

tasks she'd set them to. The only issue was that there wasn't actually that much to do. She hadn't sent out raiding parties and cooking and scavenging only took a small part of the tribe.

The rest needed direction, and Rags needed better warriors. She knew it. She'd left Tremborag's mountain with essentially her same tribe plus Garen's warriors. Well, they were certainly stronger for the inclusion of all the Redfang warriors, but the rest of her forces were just...Goblins. That was to say, they could probably overwhelm a small village, but without the Redfang warriors they had all the fighting ability of a squishy sponge.

And that was bad, especially up north. Rags had already seen that Gold-rank adventurers were far more common here, and the Human forces were nasty and well-armed and trained. She needed to give her Goblins an edge.

Thus, her dilemma. What Rags had were a lot of resources, a lot of Goblins, and a lot of enemies. All of that theoretically translated into a strong tribe to fight said enemies, but Rags had to work out how to get to that point.

What could she give her warriors? Rags already had some warriors testing out the weapons they'd stolen from Tremborag, which mainly involved one Goblin hitting things while the other Goblins stood far away and ducked whenever something happened. But magical arms did not make instant warriors, Rags knew.

Something else. What did Rags have? Well...she had crossbows.

Rags stared around at her Goblins. Many of them still had the crossbows she'd constructed with the goods taken from the Human city. Yes, that was a good thing.

She'd come up with the stone crossbow to provide her Goblins with an easy weapon to use both for hunting and fighting. It was the perfect tool for a weak Goblin tribe with limited resources, and she still kept the crossbows around for her foragers.

But what Rags needed were good weapons now, something to add to the regular force of Goblins. She could...build more crossbows?

They certainly had the parts. Right now they had around a hundred crossbows, but Rags grew excited as she thought about what would happen if they had five hundred, or a thousand. She didn't need to give them to her warriors either—the best idea would be to give them to all her Goblins who didn't normally fight! Crossbows were easy to use and aim. Why, she could

have a thousand bolts raining down on her enemies before the battle had even begun!

The idea burned bright in Rags' mind. She immediately ordered Goblins to start chopping down the tall fir and pine trees of the forest so she could make more crossbows. They'd have to get a lot of metal parts and things like screws of course, but she had a lot of tools already. Rags went to Pyrite excitedly and told him her idea.

He was sitting with Redscar and the old Goblin, overseeing the work while they ate from a small pot. Rags stared into it. It looked like they'd found a few squirrels. She took a bowl and chattered to them, explaining what she wanted.

Redscar looked intrigued by the possibilities, but the old Goblin—Rags was going to call him Whitebeard since that was what he had—scratched his chin, looking amused. And Pyrite just frowned.

“Arrows.”

That was all he said. But it immediately shattered Rags' grand plans.

Arrows. Or more accurately, bolts. Crossbows used a different sort of ammunition than regular bows, that was fair enough. But making said ammunition wasn't exactly easy, especially since you needed a good fletcher and glue.

Rags knew her Goblins could make a lot of bolts, especially with all these trees around. But they'd be wooden ones, not as powerful and would probably break after the first shot. Plus, what about fletching? A couple of thousand of birds didn't just sit around waiting for you to pluck them. And there was the issue of glue...

And the bigger issue, the one that made Rags grind her teeth as she bit into the hot meat in her stew, was carrying all the ammunition everywhere. It would be cumbersome, and they'd run out fast if they had to keep resupplying a thousand crossbows at once.

A few hundred? Very doable. Smart. But a thousand? It might work for a Human army, but Goblins didn't have an industry capable of supporting them. Rags scowled at Pyrite, but knew he was right.

“Less crossbows.”

But enough to pound her enemy. Rags wanted at least a few hundred Goblins capable of firing into her enemies in every battle. Pyrite nodded, but Redscar looked up.

“Chieftain. Need better warriors.”

He was stating the obvious. Rags scowled at him. But Redscar just jerked a thumb back towards the city they'd passed, far away.

"Strong Humans. Cavalry is..."

He hesitated. Rags saw he didn't want to say they were as good as or better than the Redfang warriors. She stared at Whitebeard. Perhaps Greybeard was a better name.

"Cavalry. Better than wolves?"

"Mm."

Greybeard smacked his lips appreciatively as Pyrite filled his bowl with more squirrel stew. He looked thoughtfully at Redscar and Rags as he chewed.

"Dangerous, Chieftain. Very. Wolves is good for surprise and raiding. Horses is good for charging. Hard to stop."

Pyrite nodded at that. Redscar looked upset, but he had to agree.

"Have to have way to stop if fight, Chieftain."

That was all he said, and thrust the *how* onto Rags. She scowled. She had no idea how these mounted warriors fought, that was the problem! She was too young, too inexperienced for all her intelligence.

Then Greybeard looked up from his bowl and stared at Rags.

"Can remember, Chieftain."

She paused and all the Goblins looked at him. Greybeard poked a nail into one ear, looking casual.

"Is big tribe. Probably can remember."

That was right! Rags could use the memory of Chieftains! She was surprised she hadn't thought about it herself—and slightly surprised Greybeard knew about the Chieftain memories. Then again, he was old.

That night, Rags lay on her back around snoring Goblins and closed her eyes. She had found something for the Goblins to do after all—she'd had them begin felling trees. It was tough work, especially since the trees were hard. But the magical axes were wonderful in that regard. Many were enchanted not to break or to be resistant to damage, and so they made wonderful tools for her woodcutters.

Rags had the idea they could build a fortress here, or maybe a village. It was just an idea, but more wood never hurt to have, especially since she was going to have her Goblins build some more crossbows anyways.

But the memory. Rags frowned as she concentrated. She knew how to recall the past, although sometimes it came to her unbidden. All she had to

do was go back—

He was a warrior, a Hob Chieftain of the Biting Blade Tribe, one of the strongest tribes of the northern plains. He stood on the open battlefield, roaring as his tribe clashed with the force of Humans. They were strong. All the Humans in the north were strong. They had come to his tribe, his lands to take it from the Goblins who lived here. Some tribes had fled, the cowards. But so long as he lived, he would resist them.

A flash of light off of metal caught the Goblin's attention. He turned and saw the [Knight] riding towards him.

Yaltes Byres. One of the great [Knights] who had slain countless Goblins. He wore silver armor, just like the rest of his famed house did. The Hob Chieftain bared his teeth. He had a big hide shield in one hand and javelins in the other. Even as the [Knight] charged him, the Hob cast his first javelin.

It was a powerful throw, one boosted by his Skills. It could kill even a normal Hob at range and pierce armor. But the [Knight] avoided the throw, urging his horse to gallop left. A miss. The Chieftain roared and threw another javelin.

This time the [Knight] took the impact with his shield. It was heavy—the Hob saw the mount falter briefly. But Yaltes came on. He was a worthy foe.

This was it. No time to throw again. The Chieftain briefly regretted not hitting the mount. But the [Knight] was so agile! His riding Skills let him dodge around a group of Goblins who came to protect their Chieftain, and mounted as he was, he was out of reach for all but Hobs. And his warhorse was armored as well.

Damn him. There was more to a warrior than just the quality of their armor. The Chieftain raised his javelin, roaring as he charged. He just had to take the first charge. He could see the silver lance pointed at his heart. He raised his shield—

And Rags sat up the next day, heart pounding, listening to the birds singing in the trees. They stopped singing fast as Goblins shot at them and claimed the eggs out of their nests. She rubbed at her eyes and cursed in Goblin.

She hated to remember her ancestors dying. It didn't hurt, but it was scary. And real.

So, even a Hob Chieftain had fallen to a mounted warrior? Rags was under no illusions as to why he'd lost. Regardless of level or equipment, the truth was that the lance was a deadly weapon. She saw that now.

All that reach! On horseback it was capable of hitting anything with so much force that Rags doubted even Garen was capable of blocking it. Your only option was to dodge or take the rider out first. But if they had armor that was hard. And what if you were fighting in a huge group? Then you were a pretty stationary target, ready to be run through.

No wonder Redscar had been so concerned. Rags immediately got to work thinking of countermeasures as her tribe woke up and got back to work scavenging, cutting down trees, and in the warrior's case, training.

Rags watched with interest as the Redfang warriors sparred and did odd things like exercise before they ate. No wonder they were different from regular Goblins.

She should probably train too—it had been a while since Rags had trained with Garen. But later. She found Redscar and got him and a few other Redfang warriors—and Pyrite, the female Goblin and Greybeard—together for a thinking session.

Their conclusions were fairly simple. The time-honored way to stop a horseman was with a long, pointy stick, preferably in great numbers. Pikemen were a common sight in armies, and if you backed that up with a shield wall you could counter a lot of things.

Rags was only too willing to get her Goblins to start fashioning long, wooden pikes out of the trees they'd felled, but she had a feeling she was making some sort of mistake. Yes, pikes were good and useful and they'd stop a charge. But the easy counter to that was to shoot the pike holders, blast them with magic, or just send a bunch of infantry at the pikes and shields and break them up so you could ride them down.

That might not be a problem if Rags had a Human army—she'd just make sure they were the best around and wouldn't break no matter what you sent at them, and would keep a group of archers in reserve. But she didn't have Humans. She had Goblins. And they couldn't deal with a face-to-face pitched battle with Humans on foot.

There had to be a better way. Rags supervised her Goblins with carpentry Skills cutting the trees into pikes. She scowled when the best [Woodworkers] among them started competing with the one [Carpenter] to see who could make the longest pikes.

Twenty-foot long pikes? Rags kicked the Goblin who smugly showed it to her. No Goblin could carry that! She doubted most Humans would be able to use it effectively!

But then Rags paused and reconsidered. No lance was going to beat a pike that long. And if two Goblins carried it...

It still didn't help with the issue of the pikes being stationary and weak to ranged attacks. Plus, the gloomy Rags saw that a group of ten pikes all lined up was great and pointy—but only in one direction. She sighed. It took three or two Goblins to lift each pike, too.

They were giggling and nudging each other as they held the pikes in place. They weren't warriors. Rags snapped at them and pointed. She told them to put the pikes with the other weapons. The Goblins grumbled, but swung the pikes up and then let them fall in the right direction. Then began running with them held horizontally—probably because that was a lot easier than holding them straight up and catching them on the branches of the few trees that still stood.

And they nearly killed a score of Goblins on the way. Rags watched all the Goblins in her camp shouting in panic as a—a wall of pointy death came straight at them. The Goblins holding the pikes laughed merrily, running full-tilt as Goblins dove out of the way. Everyone was shouting at the Goblins to stop, but no one could quite manage it. A Hob found himself in the path of the pikes and even he was forced to dive aside or risk being skewered.

And Rags stared at the Goblins causing havoc until Noears walked over and tripped them all up. In the ensuing confusion—where the offending Goblins were beat up by everyone they'd scared—Rags had another great thought.

Later that day, the Redfang warriors were intrigued and amused to be ordered to spar against a force of regular Goblins in a mock battle. Their new Chieftain, Rags, had apparently come up with a new weapon or formation she wanted to try against them.

A group of sixty elites lined up, laughing and joking. They held blunted practice weapons—bundles of sticks or crude swords made of wood—while another group mounted Carn Wolves.

It would be a slaughter, no matter what Rags had done. They had many levels and Skills on the other warriors, and even if they had real weapons, the Redfang Warriors would beat them into a pulp with sticks alone. Unless they were carrying the magical artifacts, that was. But that would be cheating.

To their amusement, the Redfang warriors saw Rags had created a traditional wall of pikes, about forty in a tight wall of Goblins. There were two Goblins or more to every pike out of necessity—they were so heavy only a Hob could lift them!

The Redfang warriors laughed hard. The pikes were dangerous, yes, but all they needed to do was fight past the tips of the pikes or flank them. If you got past the tip of the pike—which was dangerous, granted, a good [Pikeman] could run you through with one solid thrust—then you were fighting in close quarters and the pikes were useless.

Lazily, the Redfang warriors advanced while the mounted warriors sat back on their Carn Wolves. They had no desire to charge *that*.

The Redfang warriors were still joking when they realized something was wrong. The pikes were moving. Towards them. And not just slow—the warriors blinked and then got worried when they saw the wall of pointy pikes was coming at them at a dead run.

The Goblins were *charging*! That wasn't fair! And they were moving in pretty good formation—it was easy for Goblins to move together. The Redfang warriors faltered, and then moved quickly to the left.

The pikes swung left to target them. Now the Redfang warriors were getting really worried. They backed up, tried to form a shield wall. But just one look at the twenty foot long pikes rushing at them and they had a terrible premonition of how well that would work.

The Redfang warriors hesitated, turned. They tried to split up, but the pikes just split up to follow them. They were coming closer, closer—

The warriors broke and ran. The Goblins cheered as the other Goblins fled the prodding pikes, cursing. It was at this moment the mounted Redfang warriors, irate at their companions' disgrace, leapt into action.

The Carn Wolves howled as they charged around the pikes, seeking their rear. Fast they might be, but these cocky Goblins wouldn't laugh so hard when they got a few sets of teeth to their backs—

The pikes, which had been pointed in the opposite direction, rose up as the riding Redfang warriors watched. The two or three or four Goblins

assigned to each pike hauled it up fast, and then lowered it towards the riders. The riders immediately pulled their mounts away—the wolves were already shying away from the new wall of points that had appeared in front of them.

The riders broke up, circled. But the pikes came up, and suddenly they had formed a square with pikes in every direction. And then one wall of pikes came at a rider, making him curse and the Carn Wolf run yelping—

Sitting on a felled stump, Rags grinned as she stared down at the mock battle. In the end, the Redfang warriors won. The pikes were susceptible to a charge from the side if the enemy surrounded them. But this was a new group, after all, barely trained. What if you had multiple groups of pikes, all ready to charge in any direction? You could turn them fast if you trained hard enough, Rags was sure.

She glanced over at Redscar and Pyrite. The Redfang warrior was clearly unhappy, but Pyrite was smiling slightly.

“Well?”

They turned to her. Redscar grumbled.

“Weak to arrows. And magic.”

Pyrite nodded. But he looked at the Goblins. They weren’t hardened warriors like the Redfang warriors. They weren’t even proper warriors, most of them. They were just Goblins. They ran as one and moved together because that was natural to them as breathing. He looked at Rags and she knew he was seeing what she was seeing.

“Lots of pikes?”

She nodded at him. Rags stared around at the lovely forest she’d chosen to settle in. Tall trees created a canopy of pines, dusted with snow. It was a tranquil place, a place to rest and find oneself. A place where animals could live, where nature was peaceful.

A nice place. Rags eyed the trees and grinned at Pyrite.

“Get chopping.”

3.30

Some days Erin woke up with a smile on her face. She yawned, sat up, and felt the quiet of the morning wash over her.

It wasn't like how she lived back on Earth, back home. There Erin needed alarm clocks to get up, and the instant she was awake she had a phone to check, things to do. But in this world things weren't as pressing. Or maybe it was just that Erin took the time to appreciate what she hadn't before.

The cold of winter still had not let up and Erin shivered a bit as she threw off the thick wool blanket. It was scratchy, and there was no central heating in the inn. But she slept soundly each night, from being tired as much as anything else.

Yes, in some ways this world was better for her. In others—Erin touched her chest and remembered all she'd left behind.

Some days she would cry. Others she would laugh, or just try to forget. But Erin couldn't forget what she'd lost. She still remembered a house in Michigan, her mother and father, neither of whom could play chess well.

Some days she imagined her mom would wake her up because Erin had slept in till eleven or twelve. She'd be upset because Erin missed the breakfast she'd made and tell Erin not to stay up looking at chess games online, especially because it was bad for her eyes. Then her father would grow serious and talk about how Erin was pursuing her passion and how they should support her—

Erin dressed and went downstairs, caught in the memory. She only came out of it when she found herself in the kitchen and realized she had to cook.

What to make today? Erin was used to cooking for many people by now and she moved on autopilot. Biscuits and gravy, yes, that would be good. She could make a thick sauce with the remains of the meat she'd used for last night's dinner. Thick and full of energy from all the fat and stuff. That would be good. And eggs. Everyone always liked to eat good eggs.

That was how Erin spent around thirty minutes, cooking before everyone else woke up. She was brisk, efficient, and inhumanly quick in the kitchen now. Erin wondered if a professional chef would be able to make a meal faster than her.

“If I go back home, I’m definitely going on Iron Chef and kicking everyone’s butts.”

She smiled to herself as she looked at the large pot of meaty gravy and the biscuits she’d taken out of the stone oven. They were hot and steaming. She took a bowl out, filled it with gravy, and dipped the biscuit in it.

“Mm.”

It was good. Erin ate it, and then another biscuit while she listened to people waking up above her head. Miss Agnes would be down soon, slightly annoying and cheerful as always. Erin...didn’t feel like dealing with her today.

She’d done what needed doing, anyways. The pot of gravy could serve a small army, which is pretty much what descended on the inn for breakfast most mornings anyways. And the biscuits were easy enough to make that even Miss Agnes had a hard time messing it up. Unless she let them burn in the oven, that was.

And if she did, too bad! Erin filled a basket with thirty of the biscuits she’d made and found a smaller pot and a lid for the gravy. As an afterthought she looked around for a drink as well, but there was nothing portable. She wasn’t about to carry a keg.

That was what this world lacked, Erin reflected. She left the inn and walked down the snowy cobblestones, out of the inn before anyone came in or went downstairs. It was still very early, so Erin made good time through Celum’s streets.

This world lacked...certain things. Good containers, for one thing. Oh, sure, you could transport in bulk pretty well with barrels and so on, and they were remarkably waterproof, but what about water bottles, or...or covered pitchers? Then again, who would need it that badly?

“Globalization? Or is it industrialization? Modernization? Convenience?”

Probably all of the above. When you had the time to think to yourself that a mid-sized container built specifically to hold liquids was a valuable time investment, you probably had too much time on your hands. But it was convenient.

Erin sighed, and took another bite of one of the biscuits. It tasted good. But—it was sort of flat.

“Needs baking powder.”

How could a world live without baking powder? Erin was sure there was a substitute the people of this world used, but she hadn't found it yet. In the meantime, she had to live without vital necessities like cake. Or delicacies like cake. Or what Erin considered essential for mental health: cake.

It really was a shame. Erin sighed and watched her breath trail upwards, the vapor dissipating over her head. No cake. She could make cookies, though. But wait—didn't that need baking soda or something?

"Drat."

Erin glared at the ground, but without any real anger. She still felt pretty good.

Baking soda, baking powder. What was the difference between the two? One made things rise and the other...did the same thing. But there was a difference!

If only Ryoka was here. She might know how to make it. Then again, Ryoka had told Erin flat-out that she couldn't replicate half of the things from their world for lack of funding, resources, or interest. Or all of the above. But baking soda was critical! If Erin could sell cookies she'd rule the world.

Who could help her in her quest to create more unhealthy things to eat? Erin passed by a few people walking down the street, smiling at them but saying nothing, and then turned down another street. She'd gone this way so many times she didn't need to think about it.

Who made baking powder in her world? That was a really good question now that Erin thought about it. Baking powder...companies? But who invented baking powder to begin with?

"Chemists."

Erin hazarded a guess. She knew it had some weird stuff in the powder, which is why she couldn't just grind up a rock or something to make it. But if she needed this world's equivalent of a chemist, then—

For a few seconds Erin blinked. Then she slapped herself lightly in the head and nearly dropped the basket of biscuits and pot full of hot gravy. She caught herself and kicked open the door of the shop she'd arrived at.

"Octavia!"

Some people were morning people. Other people were not. Erin saw a comatose form draped over one of the tables jerk at her loud voice. Octavia raised her head and glared at Erin.

“Go melt yourself.”

“Don’t be grumpy. Wake up! It’s morning. I’ve got food.”

Erin looked around. Octavia’s alchemy shop was the usual clutter of magical potions and mess it normally was. She went into the kitchen and came out with a mostly clean bowl. Carefully, she poured some gravy into it and put some biscuits on the table in front of Octavia.

“Do you have any water? I wanted to bring something to drink, but there was nothing I could take back at the inn.”

Octavia blinked slowly at the food in front of her, still not quite focusing on the world. She took a biscuit and stared at it as if it was foreign to her.

“Water? I’ve got some...I think. Do you need to drink it? What’s for breakfast?”

Erin took that as a sign she shouldn’t drink anything in Octavia’s shop at the moment. She pushed the bowl towards Octavia.

“Gravy and biscuits. Eat. Also, I’ve got a job for you.”

That made Octavia sit up.

“Really? How much does it pay? Do you want potions or alchemical items? If you need to defer payment I can give you extremely reasonable —”

“Shut up and eat. I want baking powder. And soda. I’ll tell you what it is—you be quiet.”

Erin scowled at Octavia, but this too was part of her day. She was used to Octavia and she liked the other girl, although neither she nor Octavia would ever admit that out loud. Some people Erin just couldn’t quite gel with. Especially if they kept trying to sell her stuff like Octavia.

“Seems doable.”

That was what Octavia said as she finished the biscuits. She wiped her finger in the bowl of gravy and licked it—Erin winced a bit because Octavia hadn’t washed her hands. Then again, the [Alchemist] was scrupulously careful about washing ingredients that got on her hands off before she ate, so she was probably fine.

“I’ll take your offer up. Business is slow thanks to all those damn Goblins out and about and if you’re right about people buying this baking powder from me, I’ll gladly let you finance me.”

Erin rolled her eyes.

“Good. I’ll give you two gold coins to start with. And why is business slow? Wouldn’t tons of people be buying your potions if they’re fighting Goblins?”

“Five. If they were fighting, I’d be selling everything on my shelves. But the cities are waiting, not sending out armies, Erin. Fighting Goblins is a lot easier when you’re on top of a wall and Esthelm falling scared everyone. Once this Goblin Lord’s main army and smaller ones are located, everyone will breathe easier. Until then...”

Erin nodded.

“Three gold coins. And eight silver ones. And no arguing!”

Octavia chewed on her lip, but nodded in the end.

“I can survive on that, I suppose. Barely. But I’ll need you to make dough for me and tell me if it’s rising right.”

“You’ll be able to tell. And making the dough is easy. I’ll teach you the recipe. Stop complaining—it’s just like alchemy!”

“Hah!”

In the end, Erin paid Octavia and felt good about it. She wandered over to one side of Octavia’s shop, where the usual clutter had been cleared aside and the potions on the wall had been stored somewhere else.

“Anyone come by last night? I mean, after I left?”

Octavia shook her head.

“Nope. And no one’s come by—not after I started charging people for lingering in the store.”

Erin smiled.

“Well, if anyone does come by—”

“I get to sell them stuff if they won’t wait for you in the Frenzied Hare. Got it.”

Octavia was already poring over her ingredients, searching for the things that might work as leavening agents. She barely turned, but she did glance out of the corner of her eye as Erin walked over to the innocuous wooden door that had been set into the wall.

It was just a door, and it couldn’t possibly lead anywhere given that behind it was solid stone. And yet—Erin swung the door open, and suddenly she was staring *up* into the sky. She blinked a few times and tried to get her brain to understand that she was looking up at the sky because the door this one was connected to was lying on the back of a wagon. Then she took a deep breath and stepped through and up and—

The door closed behind Erin. Octavia shook her head, blinking a few times to regain her own sense of balance. The [Alchemist] had a very strong stomach due to all the things she had to handle and smell. But that sight made her stomach lurch a bit. And yet, it was still incredible to her.

“What a door.”

That was all she said. Then Octavia got to work. And Erin travelled many miles to a bumpy wagon travelling down a snowy, empty road towards Liscor. And the best part was that she didn’t spill the gravy.

Some things in this world were slow and wonderful. But the fast, magical moments were just as great too. As Erin stepped through the magical doorway in Octavia’s shop, she stepped *upwards*, into the sky. That was disconcerting, but Erin knew what to expect and didn’t stumble as the world twisted around her and she was suddenly walking the right way onto the back of the wagon.

“Woog.”

It still made Erin want to puke a bit every time she did it. But the experience of it—walking through a portal made by magic—was still novel.

And it was so convenient. Erin looked around the wagon and saw several people who’d been huddled in their cloaks or with a blanket and pillow look up hopefully at her arrival. She smiled brightly and raised the pot and basket.

“Good morning! Anyone want breakfast?”

“Morning, Erin.”

“Food!”

“Good morning, Miss Solstice.”

“Food! Oh. Morning, Erin.”

Yvlon, Pisces, Ksmvr, and Ceria all sat up and smiled or stared at the food Erin had brought—or did both. Pisces and Ceria both seemed especially keen for breakfast, but Yvlon and Ksmvr both eagerly accepted the food Erin had brought. The adventurers who were now the new Horns of Hammerad clustered around the pot and began sharing out the biscuits.

“Good morning, Mister Termin! Would you like some biscuits and gravy? They’re hot—I just baked them!”

The wagon driver gave Erin a gap-toothed grin as he accepted some of the food she'd brought.

"Thank you kindly, Miss Solstice. This is the finest journey I've ever had, riding along with you serving such good food morning, noon, and night."

"My pleasure. I'll bring you all lunch too, if you're not planning on stopping and eating at a village or something."

"No fear of that."

Pisces mumbled around a mouth full of food as he ate appreciatively. He gulped, and went on, ignoring the disgusted look Yvlon was giving him. Ceria was eating just as fast.

"Why should we stop? With a constant supply of food, we need not rest —"

"Except to give the horses a break."

Yvlon leaned towards Ksmvr as Ceria tried to cram a biscuit covered in gravy into her mouth. The Antinium was the only person who ate with good manners on the wagon. Two hands delicately held a biscuit up for him to nibble while a third hand held the gravy pot out for the others to dip into.

"Don't you worry about that, Miss Byres. My Skills will keep these two old plodders moving all day. A good night's sleep and rubdown is all they need, don't fret."

Termin smiled as he pointed to the two older horses that were pulling the wagon this early in the morning. Erin eyed them as she found a place to sit with the other adventurers in the back. The horses, Erma and Fox, looked old, but they both had feedbags on and seemed happy enough to eat and walk along. Besides, the wagon wasn't going *that* fast.

She smiled and sat with her friends. They ate and she leaned back. It was colder outside the city, where the wind could blow right at you. But the air felt fresher here, and the sun helped warm her through the layers of clothing she wore. There was no smell of poo that sometimes came with people living in a medieval city and using chamber pots. The scents of crowded living were gone, and there was just the empty smell of winter on the breeze.

It was a good day, and Erin was happy to be alive. She was in a good mood, although the Horns of Hammerad were decidedly less well-rested.

Ceria yawned as she finally stopped eating and stretched out. She rubbed at her back as Erin apologized for not bringing anything to drink.

“No worries. We can get water easily enough. We just need some mugs. I think we brought some with us...there they are. Now, some snow—”

“Allow me, Captain Ceria.”

“Oh, thanks, Ksmvr.”

The half-Elf let Ksmvr take the mugs, hop out of the wagon, and briskly fill them with freshly fallen snow. Erin watched appreciatively as Ceria handed Pisces half of the mugs. Both mages concentrated briefly, and in moments the snow was melting as they warmed the cups. Ceria handed the steaming mugs around and Erin passed one to Termin in the front.

“Careful, it’s hot.”

“Too hot. Springwalker, did you have to boil this water?”

“It beats drinking something nasty, Pisces. Warm isn’t good enough, even with fresh snow.”

Ceria bickered with Pisces as the two mages sipped from their drink. Erin declined her mug—she’d already drunk enough. She smiled again.

“That’s so cool you can do that. It’s so easy—what spell did you use?”

Pisces scratched one ear, looking pleased, haughty, and somewhat embarrassed for the genuine enthusiasm Erin had.

“No spell. It is hardly necessary—true, most magics require spells, but the most basic of cantrips require no spells to utilize. True, if we wanted to increase the heat emitted we would have to learn a spell, but any [Mage] with a basic understanding of the theorems of spellcastings could do the same.”

A somber silence followed Pisces’ pronouncement. Ceria rolled her eyes as everyone else deciphered his statement.

“Oh.”

That was all Erin said. She sat back as the others sipped at their drinks. After a moment, Erin felt moved to speak again.

“Did you sleep well? I can bring more blankets or pillows if you need it.”

“We’re fine, I think.”

Yvlon nodded and so did the others, although Pisces closed his mouth so suddenly Erin wondered if he had been about to ask for another pillow or three. The woman with perfect blonde hair, beautiful features, and metal fused into her arms stretched slowly, looking as if she had some back pains of her own.

“Too bad we couldn’t sleep in the inn.”

“I’ll say. A covered wagon is hardly appropriate for—”

Ceria kicked Pisces and he scowled and continued.

“—Adventurers of our caliber. Why we had to stay—”

This time Yvlon raised her foot and Pisces shut up. She glanced at Termin, but the wagon driver affected not to have heard Pisces’ comment.

“Just because we have a magic door that doesn’t mean we can waltz off whenever we feel like it, Pisces.”

“But if we remained in the inn, could we not—”

Ceria scowled at Pisces.

“We made a deal, Pisces. Sleeping in a bed in an inn over thirty miles away from here is not the same as staying with the wagon. If there’s an attack, every second counts. The same goes for the road. We have to stay with the wagon in case of trouble.”

“We could rotate a member of the group out to relax while the other three—”

“No.”

Ceria and Yvlon chorused as one. Ksmvr looked between the members of his group and nodded obediently along with them. Pisces sighed and threw up his hands. Erin had to smile—again—and Ceria grinned too. The half-Elf glanced at Erin sideways.

“Besides, there’s no inn to sleep in now. You moved the door, right, Erin?”

“It’s in Octavia’s shop now. Nowhere to sleep, Pisces, unless you fancy sleeping under one of her tables.”

The [Necromancer] opened his mouth—probably to say that was more comfortable than sleeping in a wagon in the open—and closed it. Pisces could tell when arguing was pointless. Well, sometimes.

“And have more individuals approached you about requisitioning the door for their use? I hardly feel that a lone [Alchemist] can adequately protect such a valuable means of transport.”

“I think Octavia’s pretty good at it, actually. She’s started charging people who wait around in her shop. And you know her—if anyone comes in they’ll either buy half a dozen potions or have their face explode before they go.”

Everyone smiled at that. It turned out that Yvlon and Ceria knew of Octavia by reputation, although neither adventurer had bought directly from her. Yvlon drained her mug and tossed the rest over the side of the wagon.

“She’s probably better at selling potions than she is at making them. There’s no better watchdog you could ask for.”

“Really? I thought Octavia was a really good [Alchemist]. She’s one of three.”

“In a city like Celum? Erin, that’s a lot of [Alchemists]!”

Ceria laughed at her friend. She shook her head.

“Octavia’s good at making potions for cheap. And—I guess she can make some high quality ones, but she stints too much on her ingredients, or so I’ve heard. Then again, it’s expensive to be an [Alchemist].”

“She’s naturally thrifty. Too much so. But I’ve never heard of her making a defective potion—only overselling some to gullible people.”

That made Erin feel better. She nodded as she tugged a blanket over. She’d taken them from Miss Agnes’ inn after a bit of persuasion.

“Well, she tried to charge me a fee for putting the door there, but I talked her out of it. I think she sees how valuable it is.”

“And it will be safe in her shop?”

Ksmvr looked dubious, but Ceria snorted.

“Who’s going to steal a door, let alone one attached to the wall? Besides, that’s just the anchor point. The real artifact is here.”

She rapped a fist on the plain wooden door sitting in the wagon. Everyone else nodded, and Erin patted the door appreciatively.

“Ow! Hey, does this thing have splinters?”

“Not as of such. It’s too well enchanted to break. It’s a hundred times stronger than you are...so in the worst case scenario you could rip your flesh off on a rough patch of it.”

“Aw!”

The door. Erin’s door. She rubbed at the sore palm of her hand as she stared at it.

Yes, magic was a curious thing. Some spells seemed very mundane and just like things Erin had in her world, like Ceria’s trick with warming the mugs. But some things couldn’t be copied, and were just as amazing in this world as they would be in Erin’s.

Like the door. The magical, awesome, incredible, stupendous, phantasmagorical—

Erin frowned. Was phantasmagorical the right word? Anyways, the cool door. It was Erin’s now, and that was wonderful. It meant she could go anywhere with it, conveniently and easily. At least, in theory.

It was only the second day since the door's incredible useful properties had been harnessed by Pisces and Ceria, but it was already the center of a minor power struggle in Celum. Of course, when Erin and the Horns of Hammerad had first stepped back through it into the Frenzied Hare in Celum, everyone had been dumbstruck. News of the artifact the Horns of Hammerad had recovered had spread like lightning.

You'd think everyone would be *happy* a magical teleportation-portal door had been created. But the first visitor Erin had received as she and the Horns of Hammerad were having a great dinner that very night in the inn had been a man, a wealthy [Trader] who told Erin he saw big possibilities in her door. He wanted to buy it for a hundred gold coins.

She refused. He upped it to two hundred, and then six hundred coins when she kept refusing. In the end he had to leave, disappointed. That was the start.

The next person to arrive was a rather more influential [Merchant] who told Erin he represented the Merchant's Guild in the city. He offered her six thousand gold coins for the door immediately, and when she refused he tried to strike a deal with her.

The merchants and traders and indeed, shopkeepers and craftspeople of Celum wanted to use the door as, well, a door into Liscor. If it could be kept open they would reap huge profits that they would share with Erin, all assured her. But just as Erin was considering this, a Runner had come to her inn demanding to speak with her.

Fals, the nice Runner guy that Ryoka had told Erin about came with Garia to plead their case with Erin. They did *not* want her to let the merchants use the door for anything. After all, it would totally destroy the Runners Guild's traffic between Celum and Liscor. The last thing Erin wanted was to put anyone out of work, but then the *Mage's Guild* had come by to tell Erin that if she wanted to gain a monopoly on messages between Liscor and Celum, she had another thing coming. And then—

And then Erin had clocked one of the merchants and everyone had sort of backed up a bit. But the issue over the door was clear: it was a valuable object and everyone wanted to use it. So that night Erin had had to fend off multiple people wanting to talk to her, people she had never met before except for Garia and Fals.

Fals was nice, and the [Merchants] and envoy from the city's council had been sickeningly fawning. The [Mage] was full of himself until he

realized Pisces and Ceria might actually have more levels than him—plus they were Wistram graduates and he was not. Then he was so obsequious Erin wanted to throw up.

Relief had come from Pisces of all people. Undeterred by the argument, he'd managed to affix the anchoring spell or whatever it was to an actual door and harness the teleportation spell to create a portal rather than just transport people. Apparently it wasn't that hard, or Pisces was just as smart as he said. According to Ceria, it was a bit of both.

What Pisces had discovered was that powerful the door might be, but it drank more mana than a sponge. It could teleport someone back and forth many times, and even a group of people. But eventually it *would* run out, and when it did it would take a long time to recharge.

Not only that, but the amount of mana required to activate the spell was understandably high. Both Pisces and Ceria had tried to recharge the door and only managed to juice it up enough for the Horns of Hammerad to make a one-way trip to the wagon to guard it overnight. And they'd still had to use a few mana potions.

So what was the conclusion? Well, the Merchant's Guild still wanted to use the door as a faster way of transport, the Runner's Guild and Mage's Guild were afraid Erin would bulk transport things like letters which didn't have much mass and could be teleported easily, and Erin realized she didn't trust Miss Agnes with the door in her inn.

So she'd told everyone to go away and put the door in Octavia's shop. As for the rest...

"I promised Fals and Garia—the Runner's Guild—that I wouldn't transport any letters or deliveries. Only personal stuff I'm using. I said the same thing to the Mage's Guild so they're happy. But the city wanted to use my door for emergencies, they said."

"The city or the mayor? Is Celum ruled by a council or a mayor? I thought they were like Remendia and Ocre and had elected leaders."

"Nope. Mayor. And guess who wants my door?"

"A lot of [Merchants] and guild leaders?"

Erin nodded miserably. Pisces snorted and Ceria rolled her eyes.

"So they want to take it from you. Predictable."

"Not *take*...but they want me to pay fees for using it. Or...I could let them use the door if they need it to, I dunno, transport supplies or do

something really important. They'd be able to use it in case of emergencies, they said."

Pisces looked as if he was ready to spit. He pursed his lips and sniffed before wiping his nose on his robe.

"Hah. If you agreed to that, then no doubt every day the city would face a crisis of unprecedented severity that required usage of the door."

Erin nodded sadly. She had to be selfish or the door would be useless.

"I told them it's mine and they can't charge me because I'm not going through the gates."

Yvlon's eyebrows rose.

"Really? And what did they say?"

The [Innkeeper] fidgeted on the cart, avoiding anyone's eyes.

"I uh, hinted that you, the Horns of Hammerad, would be really upset if they did. So they backed down."

Silence. And then Ceria laughed.

"Hah!"

Pisces and Termin guffawed and Yvlon smiled. Ksmvr just looked around, confused.

"I do not understand the joke. Pisces, please explain it to me."

Ceria shook her head, and Erin blinked as her hair caught the light. She was still beautiful, too much so for this world. Otherworldly.

"Well, that settles that. I guess the only thing you've got to worry about is it being stolen, although Pisces is right. Anyone with a brain will see that the door's useless if they steal the anchor. People without a brain are the ones you should be worried about, though."

Erin looked away as Ceria smiled at her.

"I don't think that's a problem. I talked with Wesle and the captain of the Watch and they told me they'd keep an eye on Octavia's shop. Plus, no one likes to try and rob an [Alchemist] because all kinds of things can happen with all those potions lying around."

Ceria nodded.

"That's true. Good thing you've got a [Guardsmen] for a friend. In Celum, I mean."

"Excuse me, but I still do not understand the joke. Pisces, will you explain it to me?"

"Former [Guardsmen], actually. He quit his job."

"Really?"

Erin smiled as the Horns of Hammerad exclaimed.

“Yeah. He says he’s earning a ton more than he ever did as a [Guardsmen] and he likes acting better. He wants to form a troupe—a group that goes from city to city to perform. They’re stuck in Celum now, but since I can go back whenever, I’ll teach them more plays and they’ll keep practicing.”

“That’s wonderful, it sounds like you’ve really had an impact on the city, Erin.”

“Yeah! And with this door I’m gonna get a lot of customers when I get back. I have big plans—but you were saying it might be useful in other ways, right?”

“Comrade Pisces. I do not understand the j—”

“*Shut up!*”

Pisces shouted at Ksmvr. The Antinium fell silent for a second.

“If I am silent, will you explain the joke?”

He got along well with Pisces, in the sense that he was the only person who annoyed Pisces and not the other way around. Erin waited patiently, grinning as Pisces laboriously explained the joke to Ksmvr who had a weak grasp of humor at best.

“Ah. I see. This is more humor to raise morale. I will remember it. Thank you.”

Pisces somewhat huffily adjusted his position as he lounged on a few pillows.

“You’re welcome. Now, as I was saying, this door *is* useful. I have no idea if it has an upper range, but I suspect with a modicum of effort on my and Springwalker’s part we could form multiple anchoring points for usage.”

“What? You mean I could go to all kinds of cities?”

Erin was enthralled by the idea. But Pisces raised a cautionary hand.

“A few. Very few, I believe. Connecting to multiple points risks entanglement, and that could result in a tangled web of magic that could have any number of effects. I would hesitate to create more than four focal points. But I suggest that if you link the door to two more cities for very sporadic usage, you might consider giving one anchoring point to our group.”

“Really? Why?”

“Remember how Pisces said the door could be used as an emergency getaway, Erin? Well, if he can make something easy to carry, we could use the door to get away if we’re ever in trouble, in a dungeon, say.”

Erin paused. She looked over at Ceria and her eye caught on the half-Elf’s skeletal hand. Erin couldn’t help it. She knew it was rude to stare, but sometimes she did stare at Ceria. Her hand, and her friend. Erin didn’t have many friends and she’d been overjoyed to see Ceria—and Pisces and Yvlon and Ksmvr again. When she thought of the dungeon, of Skinner—

“Of course I’ll let you have one. If it works. I mean, would it work for multiple people and if you’re far away or underground?”

Pisces sniffed all-importantly as eyes turned towards him.

“Of course there will be necessary experimentation. And yes, such a fallback would have limitations. But better to have it than not, agreed?”

Everyone nodded. Erin felt happy at the idea—not only could she go to more cities, she might be able to help her friends! But she’d have to be careful with the door, definitely. Maybe she could put it upstairs, so people didn’t use it by accident? Or—could she build a basement in the inn? Surely Klbkch could help her with that, right? She had the money to pay the Antinium now too.

And then it happened. Erin was sitting up in the wagon, about to ask Pisces whether the anchor stones would work if she’d exhausted the door’s power for the day, or whether she’d need to always keep a reserve—when she felt the world explode.

Erin had been in a fire drill, countless fire drills and earthquake drills in school. Even when she knew one was scheduled, she hated the moment of fear and panic that occurred when every single bell started ringing as loudly as possible. But that was only external sound, loud and frightening but only that. Bells *in* your head were a different matter.

It was as if every alarm clock, siren, fire alarm and noisemaker suddenly went off in Erin’s head at once. She doubled over, clutching her head and crying out in surprise and fear. Dimly, Erin heard Ceria and Termin doing the same.

“Miss Solstice? Erin, is something wrong? Are we in danger?”

Ksmvr was shaking Erin by the shoulder. She tried to explain, tried to speak past the terrible fear in her head.

“Something’s—”

And then she saw someone standing in the cart's way. Instantly, Ksmvr let go of Erin and reached for the blades at his side. The Horns of Hammerad leapt off the wagon, the genial atmosphere of moments ago forgotten. There was danger, and here was someone who *had not been standing there a moment ago*.

"Teleportation? Ceria, how bad—"

"Ceria?"

"Bad! It's—we have to retreat."

"I will attack first. Please, withdraw if I am slain."

"What's happening? My [Dangersense]—wait, is it coming from him?"

A confused babble of voices broke through the ringing in Erin's head. She managed to make the sound lessen, and stood up on the cart as the horses neighed, sensing the alarm around them.

A man was standing in the middle of the snowy road. He shouldn't have been there. The roads were practically deserted in the wake of the Goblin armies roaming about, and what travelers there were didn't dare move alone unless they were Runners.

And this man—was no runner. Erin's eyes widened when she saw him. He stood over six feet tall, a giant. He was powerfully built, imposing, with the body that every man probably dreamed of having. He looked like a superhuman athlete, and yet he was *old*. He had a white beard, white robes that were brilliant, made of some incredibly rich fabric that seemed brighter and cleaner than the snow itself—

And two eyes of mismatched color. Cerulean and heliotrope. Blue and violet, shimmering colors like celestial bodies shining forth from his pupils. Erin hesitated because she thought they looked so *familiar*...

But he had not been on the road a moment ago. He had appeared and that was terrifying in itself. One second the road was empty, and in the moment between looking elsewhere and turning back, he was there, as if he'd been there all along or he'd been in the peripherals of your vision and you hadn't noticed until now.

And the [Dangersense] in Erin's head blared. It was telling her of danger, immediate and pressing. She stared at the man as he stood silently in front of the wagon. Danger. Danger. *Danger*. It was a cacophony of ringing alarms.

The message was clear: do not fight this man. Run away. Do not fight. You will die.

And yet the Horns of Hammerad formed a semicircle around the cart, weapons raised. Yvlon had no armor, Pisces and Ceria had only the magic that shimmered around their palms. Ksmvr held weapons in the three arms he possessed. They were shouting.

At Erin?

“Get through the door, Erin! You too, wagon driver!”

“You there. Identify yourself.”

“Don’t attack! Not yet! Pisces—”

“Through the door, Erin! Now!”

Erin wanted to move, but she wanted to stay as well. It was just an old man. True, one that looked like—well, looked like no actual Human being she’d ever seen but—was he dangerous? How could he be?

The old man was just staring at her. Her, out of all the others. He was looking up at the blue sky, around at the snowy landscape, the empty road, at the wagon, and then at Erin. As if he was taking in the sights. But he seemed to be annoyed by all the shouting. He raised one hand.

“Silence.”

And there was. Because everyone was waiting to see what he was going to do next. Erin saw Termin trying to soothe his horses. She looked at the door, and knew she could seize the handle and be in Octavia’s shop in a moment. But what about her friends? And couldn’t he follow them?

“Greetings, Human.”

Ksmvr spoke in the silence, ignoring the annoyed look the man gave him. He lowered the short sword and daggers in his hands as he nodded to the old man.

“We are Silver-ranked adventurers. The Horns of Hammerad. May I ask why you have blocked our path?”

“I wish to speak with her.”

Erin felt a jolt as his finger pointed straight at her. The reaction of her friends was immediate. They closed ranks in front of the wagon.

“May I ask why?”

“It doesn’t matter, does it?”

Ksmvr seemed to freeze up as the multi-colored stare swung towards him. And then Erin saw another aspect of the old man. He stared down at Ksmvr as if he was, well, a bug. He looked at Ceria, Yvlon, Pisces, all clearly adventurers, with the same casual disdain for their existence. Only Erin he looked at with...

“Move aside, adventurers. Or I will move you.”

That was a threat. Erin felt herself shiver. Ceria’s voice was very serious as she held a hand up.

“We don’t want...to fight. But unless you tell us why you want to speak with Erin—and we’re sure you don’t intend her harm—we can’t let you do anything, Human.”

“I intend to explain nothing to you, half-Elf.”

There was no compromise in his voice. Erin saw Ceria tense.

“You don’t have a choice here. Tell us why you want Erin.”

“Otherwise?”

The question caught everyone off guard. The old man looked at Ceria. She hesitated.

“What—do you mean?”

“Otherwise, what? If I refuse, what will you do? Will you prevent me from speaking with this girl?”

“If necessary. If you refuse to cooperate, we will have no choice but to fight.”

Yvlon called that out. She was holding the sword in her hands without a sign that the metal in her arms was bothering her. And her gaze was intent on the old man’s face. She sensed it too, Erin realized. Whoever this old man was, he wasn’t—normal.

For a moment the old man sighed. He looked impatient, annoyed—but not the least bit intimidated. He cast his gaze towards the sky, thought for a moment, and then...nodded.

“That would be the quickest way. Very well.”

What happened next was too fast for Erin to follow. In the moments afterwards as she ducked and Termin yelled in fright beside her, Erin realized what had happened.

The instant the old man had said that, Ceria had acted first. She’d raised her skeletal hand and fired a spike of ice straight at his midriff. It was a killing attack, but it hadn’t touched him.

Instead, the spear of ice had shattered midflight, filling the air with shards of ice that bounced off the wagon. Erin dared to peek her head up and saw the Horns of Hammerad staring at the old man.

He hadn’t moved from that spot. He’d only raised his hand. Erin saw three fingers pointed at the spot where the [Ice Spike] had been shattered by something.

“[Stone Dart]. A low level spell, but all I am capable of here. However, it seems only ah, Tier 2 spells will be necessary here at any rate.”

That was all he said. Erin felt the Horns of Hammerad pause—and then Ceria raised her hand and attacked and the battle began.

“[Ice Dart]!”

Erin had never seen Ceria fire so many ice darts so quickly. They flew at the old man like a rain of missiles—and he blocked them. His hand moved up, caught and shattered a piece of ice flying towards his face, one towards his chest—

So quick! How was he doing it? Erin saw the old man step backwards casually among the hail of missiles. Then he raised his other hand and spoke.

“[Mud Slap].”

A splash of dark brown liquid splattered across the distance between him and Ceria. Erin saw her friend cry out, but it was just mud. In her eyes. But it made the rain of darts stop and then Erin saw what the old man had been blocking them with.

A rock. Just a flat stone. The old man tossed it on the ground.

“[Call Object]. Next?”

He had only a moment to say that. From his left and right Ksmvr and Yvlon came charging at him, blades swinging. The old man nodded, swept his hands out. A flurry of snow blew at both warriors.

“[Frozen Wind].”

They ran through it, half-blinded, but still ready to strike. But then something happened. Erin saw Yvlon and Ksmvr both go down, crashing to the ground but she didn’t see *how*. And then Pisces—

He was raising the dead. Termin cried out and his horses tried to drag the wagon around as eight skeletons burst out of the ground. Pisces grinned as they tore themselves out of the earth—

“[Stone Dart]. Bludgeoning type.”

The old man pointed and eight stones appeared and struck each skeleton. Not in the head or ribs, but at their spines as they attempted to form themselves. The stones shattered bone and broke the delicate assembly process. Each skeleton collapsed onto the ground, the animation spell failing in an instant.

“Pisces! I’ll—”

“[Stone Dart].”

Another bit of stone struck Ceria in the head as she wiped the last of the mud from her eyes. She crumbled, and the old man sighed.

“Do modern mages not know any protective spells? Or are you truly untrained amateurs?”

He turned to point at Yvlon who was getting to her feet—

And leaned backwards as a burning sword nearly ran him through. Pisces drew back the rapier in his hands as magical flames danced along its length. Erin gasped—she hadn’t seen him move, but he’d covered the distance between him and the old man in an instant!

“[Flash Step]. And a variation of [Flame Rapier]. Well, interesting.”

The old man commented as he stepped backwards. Pisces thrust, but the old man raised his hands and ten [Stone Darts] flew from every finger. Erin heard a curse and Pisces seemed to appear several steps away. His robe and the arm beneath it were cut, but he was uninjured.

“Come, then.”

Pisces took a step to run the old man through—

And tripped.

This time Erin saw what had happened. As he moved and his form vanished, a tiny, twisting loop of grass had sprung up in the snow. It snagged his foot as he moved forwards at lightning speed. The grass strands broke, but it sent Pisces crashing and tumbling to the ground.

“[Tripgrass].”

The old man said it belatedly, as if announcing the spell was an afterthought. The old man walked over to Pisces. The young [Necromancer] snarled and raised his hands—

And the old [Mage] kicked him in the head. Erin shouted, but Pisces just fell back unconscious. Not...dead. He couldn’t be.

The old man turned towards Erin. Then he glanced to one side.

“Ah.”

Yvlon and Ksmvr charged towards him, the Antinium throwing one of the daggers in his hands. Again, a precise strike from the [Stone Dart] easily deflected the dagger. But they were closing in. Yvlon raised her sword with a cry, and the man clapped his hands together.

“[Flash].”

This time Erin went blind. She clapped a hand to her eyes and tried to blink to see. She heard shouting, and then a choking sound. When she could

see past the spots in her eyes she looked again and saw Yvlon on the ground. The woman was choking. Choking on—snow?

“[Snowball]. Or is it [Create Snow]? Ah, either one works.”

The old man had *hit* Yvlon in her open mouth with snow. It was filling her throat and she was trying to throw up, get it out. Ksmvr was the only one left on his feet.

“Die.”

He swung his blade towards the old mage’s head. Flames engulfed him.

“[Flame Jet].”

The old man’s voice came from the center of the flames. Ksmvr scythed forwards, but the flames hadn’t just burned him. They’d screened the old man and he walked past Ksmvr on the left, raising his hands again. As the Antinium turned, ten shards of ice pierced his chest. Not deep, but they sent him staggering back.

“Throw down your weapon, insect.”

“Never.”

Ksmvr raised his blade and then a blast of water struck him in the face. It made him overbalance and stumble back again. And a stone was right behind his left foot, hovering there. Ksmvr fell backwards. He tried to roll over—

And couldn’t. Erin saw grass growing all around him, looping around his arms, pulling him to the ground and holding him there. Each blade of grass was weak, but together it enmeshed him so thoroughly he couldn’t move.

The old man walked over to Ksmvr. The Antinium spoke to him, lying flat on his back.

“If you let me live I will not cease until you or I lie dead.”

“Yes, your kind is like that.”

The old man pointed down at Ksmvr. He opened his mouth and then tilted his head sideways. The dagger flashed past his head, missing completely.

Erin gaped. The old man flicked his attention to Ksmvr, and then stepped away from the Antinium. He nodded at the dagger which was now buried in the snow.

“Hm. You have a Skill, don’t you? But perfect aim is meaningless if you allow me time to dodge. Without more Skills you would not be able to strike even a cat with such a throw.”

He sounded so nonchalant. He'd taken apart her friends with basic spells in an instant and—

On the wagon, Erin hesitated. Part of her told her to run, to get away and be safe. Her sensible self rationalized it. He wanted her for some reason. If she ran, the old man might let her friends live.

But not Ksmvr. So Erin clenched her fists. She leapt from the wagon with a yell—

And tripped as something snagged her leg going over the side. Erin had only a moment to yelp before she smacked into the ground hard. She groaned—she hadn't landed in the snow, only on frozen ground. And falling from a wagon headfirst *hurt*. If she hadn't managed to catch the fall on her arms she might have broken her skull, but she felt like her arms were broken instead.

“[Tripgrass]. Again.”

Erin had to get up. She pushed herself up groggily and saw the old man looming over her. She yelped, threw a punch with all her strength.

He caught it. It was a [Minotaur Punch] and he caught it. Erin blinked at the incredible strength in the man's body. True, he looked like he was strong enough for it, but—

He released her, and Erin stumbled back. She stared at him, fists half-raised. She felt like she had long ago, in front of Gazi. As if anything she did would be useless. The old man stared around, and then at Termin. The wagon driver was sitting white-faced in his driver's seat.

“Will you try to fight as well?”

Termin stared back, paralyzed by fear. The white-bearded stranger nodded, and turned to Erin. She tensed—

And he held up an iPhone.

“You are Erin Solstice, aren't you? Explain this to me.”

Erin stopped. All processes went on immediate halt. She lowered her hands. Her mind went blank. She stared at the small, metallic object in the old man's hands. Its screen was glowing, and it looked so familiar to her. But—

She stared at the old man. At the iPhone.

“That's an iPhone.”

“Yes. It is. And it seems to be malfunctioning, although I copied it completely.”

“That's Ryoka's iPhone.”

The world had stopped making sense. Erin stared at the old man while she waited for someone to wake her up from the dream she was having. He nodded to her, impatient.

“A copy. See—this.”

The old man pointed to the small, glowing screen. Erin peered down at the app his finger was pointing at.

“Oh. Safari. That’s an...that’s the internet app.”

“Is it?”

The old man frowned at Erin. He tapped the app and a screen popped up, glowing, white, before the typical ‘no internet’ page flashed on screen.

“You see? I am missing something for it to work. What connection do I need to obtain?”

“Um.”

Erin stared blankly at the screen, and then at the frowning face in front of her. She felt like her brain was trying to work a million miles a second while crawling along at a snail’s pace. She answered automatically as best she could.

“Well, you need internet. But uh, you don’t have internet here. No one in this...this world does. So...it’s not gonna work.”

“I see. That is inconvenient. Well then, am I to assume these other functions do not work for the same reason?”

The old man clicked a button and the iPhone went back to the menu screen. Erin peered at the iPhone, nodding her head.

“Youtube? Oh—that’s for watching videos. Yeah, it needs internet too.”

“But there are videos on this device.”

“Oh—those are downloaded. Uh, they’re part of it. Youtube needs...the internet.”

“Ah. And the store? This one?”

“Spotify? Yeah. Same problem.”

“I see. How tedious. Is there any other function I may have missed?”

“What?”

“I have listened to every song and watched every ‘video’ on this device. I have solved the riddle of this particular function—”

“You mean the app? 2048? The game?”

“Ah, that’s what they’re called? App. Hm. And yes, it was a quite entertaining game, or rather, logic puzzle. But is there anything else I can do with this device?”

“Well, you could—hold on.”

Erin raised her hand and stared at it. Then she slapped herself as hard as she could. Her head rang a bit.

“Ow!”

“That looked painful.”

“It was. Sorry. Well...you can take notes with the iPhone. See here?”

“Ah yes. And record what is spoken. A useful function, no doubt.”

“And—oh, Ryoka had Triple Town. See—”

Erin found the iPhone nearly snatched out of her hands. The old man stared down at the screen, eyes bulging.

“How did you *do* that? I couldn’t fathom how I did it once. But you’ve changed the screen!”

“Hm? You didn’t know? You can change the screen since there are more apps. See? You swipe left. Like this...”

“Swipe left. Fascinating.”

Erin stared at the old man as he clumsily moved his fingers across the screen. She felt compelled to reach for the one straw of rationality she had in this moment.

“I’m surprised...Ryoka didn’t tell you how the iPhone worked. Because this is totally something she gave you, right?”

“Hm? Candy Crush? Intriguing. Oh yes, I received this from her.”

“Ah.”

The young woman nodded a few times. The old man was mumbling to himself, mostly along the lines of ‘fascinating’, or ‘yes, this certainly deserves closer study’. Erin stared at him.

“What’s your name?”

“Teriarch. Mm. I can see there is much I have yet to explore. Tell me, I encountered a terrible problem when I went here. To settings, see? And I pressed—”

“Ooh, yeah. Reset. Don’t do that. It gets rid of everything.”

“So I had noticed. But why does it exist?”

“Um. So you can put other things on the device? If you had the internet I mean.”

“Really? How?”

Erin stared at Teriarch. She stared into his multicolored eyes and wondered if today was a good day or not.

“Uh, well, you can’t here. It’s impossible.”

“Ah. Well then, I shall make do with these new...apps. Thank you for your help, Erin Solstice.”

“Oh. No problem...have we met before?”

Teriarch paused. He raised his head from the screen he'd been staring at obsessively and looked at Erin. For the first time he looked into her face, rather than just at her as an object to be interacted with. And he frowned.

“You do look...familiar. How odd. I should know anyone I have encountered. But I...hrm. I think we have met.”

Erin nodded slowly. He seemed familiar. But from where?

“Well...you're a friend of Ryoka? Or she knows you?”

“She has performed tasks for me before, yes.”

“Oh. I see. You're her...mysterious client?”

Teriarch frowned, and Erin realized she might have violated Ryoka's contract of silence or whatever. But Ryoka had never told her who Teriarch was, just that she'd met with someone who was powerful and could cast magic. Teriarch studied Erin slowly and nodded.

“Yes. I am a...mage. Of quite significant ability.”

“I can tell. Um. Are my friends going to be alright?”

Teriarch looked dismissively at the Horns of Hammerad. Erin saw Yvlon was on her knees, still coughing. She thought Pisces had one eye open, but both were closed when she looked again. Ceria was still out and Ksmvr was watching them silently.

What should she do now? Teriarch was clearly absorbed in the iPhone. He kept asking Erin what various apps Ryoka had downloaded did. Ryoka had quite a few games on her iPhone. More than one Erin was tickled to know Ryoka played, or had played in the past.

It was surreal. Teriarch was just...interested. He kept *harrumphing* importantly, but he was keenly fascinated with the iPhone. He had just beaten up her friends, but he'd left them alive. He didn't seem evil. More like...odd? And Erin kept staring at him, feeling that tickling in her memory.

But something prompted Erin to break off from her explanation of how to play Angry Birds and frown. The warning bells in her head hadn't died away. Rather, it was as if they had faded during the fight to let her think and act without being overwhelmed, but now that it was over they were still blaring loudly, telling her—

“Are you um, going to kill us?”

Teriarch paused and stared at Erin with a mixture of indignation and confusion.

“Me? Why would I kill you?”

“Well, you attacked us.”

“Yeah.”

That came from behind Teriarch and Erin. She turned and saw Ceria was standing upright, supported by Pisces on one side and Yvlon on the other. Ksmvr was still tied to the ground, calling out for aid now that the danger had passed.

“Help. I am stuck to the ground.”

“Ah. See, Erin Solstice? Your friends are alive and mostly unharmed.”

Teriarch gestured as Ksmvr sat up. Ceria blinked a few times at him, eyes partially unfocused. Erin hoped she didn’t have a concussion—Ceria just looked woozy.

“You attacked us. Why?”

“You were in my way.”

The sky was blue. The grass was green. It was a matter-of-fact statement that made Yvlon grit her teeth angrily. Erin just stared at Teriarch, feeling that same disconnect. He went on, arrogant, trying to score three stars in a level of Angry Birds.

“Explaining would have been a waste of my time. And this was entertaining, however easy it was.”

The Horns of Hammerad stared at Teriarch. He frowned as one of the pigs escaped destruction.

“How did you do it?”

Pisces was next to speak. He stared at Teriarch wide-eyed, with more respect than Erin had ever seen in him in his life.

“You—all you were using were Tier 2 spells at best. But the style of your spellcasting—”

“Elementary. Any competent mage should be able to do as much, if not so quickly or with the same mana supply. You should be ashamed of yourselves not to have any counters against such low level spells.”

Teriarch shrugged. He nodded at Ceria.

“You should go to Wistram, half-Elf. With a decade of studying you may become a powerful mage yet.”

“We did go to Wistram.”

“Really?”

Teriarch's eyebrows rose in disbelief. He stared at Pisces but seemed to ascertain that the mage was not lying. Teriarch snorted angrily.

"Standards have fallen greatly, then. Your spellcasting was beyond inferior. That was a decent attack with a sword I suppose, but unless you *are* a [Spellsword] or some other mage-warrior hybrid, I suggest you focus on magic."

"Um."

Erin raised her hand. She just felt like it was the thing to do. All eyes focused on her. Erin tapped her head.

"My [Dangersense] is still going off. Are you really not going to kill us, Teriarch?"

"Me? No. But...hrm."

Teriarch stared off into the distance. His lips moved soundlessly, then he nodded.

"Ah. That explains much of your hostility. Your senses were alerted by a nearby Goblin Army. It is passing this way."

"An army?"

The Horns of Hammerad went pale. Erin felt a jolt of fear in her chest, but she looked at the wagon. It was Termin of all people who wailed and clutched at his hair.

"Goblins! What will I do? Fox and Erma will be eaten for sure!"

Fox and Erma? Erin remembered those were Termin's horses. She stared at the animals, feeling a jolt in her chest. Could they push the animals through the door? But if they did—what if the Goblins opened the door? Could they seal it off, then? But how would they get back?

Teriarch raised one eyebrow as Yvlon tried to convince Termin they had to leave his mounts behind. Pisces already had the door up and was yelling at Ksmvr to help him find a spot to hide it from the Goblins. Erin saw Teriarch tap Ceria on the head when no one was watching. Ceria frowned, blinked, and seemed to regain focus.

"Um, Mister Teriarch."

He glanced at her, still holding the iPhone in one hand.

"Yes?"

"Can you help us? I dunno, somehow evade the Goblins?"

"You should be able to do it yourselves without my help. Unless—are you really planning to flee?"

"What would you do?"

Ceria stared at Teriarch. He looked incredulous.

“This is winter. The Goblin army is marching this way, but they are hardly filled with adept trackers and they do not know you are here. Conjure a snowstorm and evade them.”

The half-Elf shook her head instantly.

“We can’t do that. Pisces and I—neither of us know [Snowstorm] as a spell, and we’re not nearly high-level enough to cast it, let alone to affect such a large—”

“What are you talking about?”

Teriarch looked impatient. He began to lecture Ceria, much to Erin’s incredulity.

“[Snowstorm]? Why do you need to *create* snow? If you were standing in a jungle I could see the need, but you have an ample supply of snow right here. Use that. Even a Tier...1 spell should do.”

“How?”

Ceria’s ears drooped slightly as Teriarch’s glare pierced her in place.

“Are you *really* Wistram mages? Here. Like this. You—[Necromancer]! Come over here and help your friend!”

Pisces ran over as Teriarch walked over to a large expanse of snow and began ordering Ceria about. Erin stared at him as Yvlon and Ksmvr and Termin all stopped what they were doing to watch.

There wasn’t too much happening. Teriarch was just pointing to the ground at something the two mages could see and berating them. They kept flinching as he grew more and more impatient with them.

“There. Anchor the spell there and cast multiple incarnations of it—no, not like that! Why are you using your mana so poorly? A proper spell is efficient! And you—half-Elf! You’re wasting the energy of your spell with uncontrolled winds. The two of you cast in tandem like—well, that is barely acceptable.”

Suddenly, a gust of wind blew up, carrying a huge amount of snow with it. Teriarch nodded as Erin and the others gasped. The wind began to blow, and as he lent his power to the wind spells, it began to blow down the road. Erin turned to Termin, and pointed to the wagon.

“Um. Let’s get out of the way?”

He stared at her, face pale as the snow began whipping into the air. Then he scrambled towards the driver’s seat with the others.

The Goblin army was a massive force, thousands strong. Black-armored warriors marched with the undead, grim, sullen because they hadn't been able to find any easy prey to kill and eat. Marching in the winter was bad enough with armor, but the stench of the undead made the Goblin warriors upset.

And what was worse, they'd run into a snowstorm. The Goblins grumbled and their scouts withdrew to form a tight perimeter around their army. If they ran into anything in the storm they'd kill it. But they could still follow the road so they pressed onwards until they reached the other side. It was a brief snowstorm, the Goblins reflected. But they took no more notice of it; they had Humans to kill, and other Goblins too for that matter.

Far away, the wagon Termin was driving rumbled to a stop as Erma and Fox panted in the snow. Erin hopped off the wagon and slowly walked up to the small ridge to see the last of the Goblin army disappearing in the distance.

"Wow."

That was all she said. She turned back and saw Teriarch, sitting austere on top of the wagon with an iPhone in hand, looking more out of place than anything she'd ever seen as Ceria and Pisces tried to ask him ten thousand questions at once.

"How did you learn to use magic like that? I've never seen spellcasting so—refined! And the way you do it..."

"It is one method of practicing magic. I consider it to be the most efficient. It is certainly superior to your...attempts. How have you not been taught the various schools of magic if you studied at Wistram?"

"We were expelled. We studied for years but...we never fully graduated."

"We came close. I daresay we were as good as most mages, but Spingwalker is right. Yet we were allowed to claim the name. We are recognized Wistram mages still."

That was Ceria and Pisces' guilty confession, but it was hardly as surprising to Erin as the revelation that Teriarch was some kind of super-

mage. Or an Archmage. Apparently magic, which Erin understood to be like math in some respects, was all about understanding spells. And Teriarch had shown Pisces and Ceria some shortcuts in magic, or things which he considered basic and they considered miraculous.

“Hmf. Even then. Any first-year student would have had such things drilled into them. At least, if Wistram is acting as a proper institution for education. What happened to Archmage Zelkyr? He would never have let mages sink so low.”

“Archmage...he’s dead. He died over a century ago. Two centuries, I think.”

“Oh...”

Both Pisces and Ceria had that huge-eyed, slack jawed expression of disbelief Erin was used to getting from time to time. She supposed she should be behaving the same way. Did that mean Teriarch was really old?

“Well, refine yourselves with what I have shown you. Your Skills and... classes should do the rest. You, half-Elf, study the spell I marked in that spellbook. It should compliment your ice magic skills. And you, [Necromancer]...”

He somehow knew what magic both Ceria and Pisces used at a glance. Teriarch sighed.

“We hardly need more necromancers. But I suppose your control of magic is quite good for one so young. Keep practicing.”

He stepped off the wagon. Ksmvr and Yvlon stared at him. Teriarch nodded to Erin. She hesitated.

“Oh. You’re gonna go? Um. Thanks?”

Was that the appropriate response? Teriarch nodded regally to her.

“And thanks to you as well for showing me how this device works. Farewell, Erin Solstice. We shall not meet again.”

That sounded sort of weird. And ominous. Teriarch began to stride through the snow, but Pisces leapt off the wagon and chased after him.

“Master Teriarch! Sir!”

Pisces flung himself at the snow at Teriarch’s feet. The old man looked more annoyed than anything else.

“What is it?”

“Please take me on as your apprentice! To learn from someone who lived during the time of Archmage Zelkyr—I would do anything for such an honor!”

Teriarch stared down at Pisces as the young man looked up hopefully at him. Erin's jaw was open. Ceria looked like she was considering doing the same thing. Teriarch stared down at Pisces.

"No."

Then he turned and walked away. Pisces ran after him, but it was as if Teriarch was suddenly walking at a different speed than Pisces. He strolled along, but then his form grew further and further away, until he was a speck in the distance. Then he was gone, and Pisces and the others were left alone in the snow.

In the silence that followed Erin wondered whether this was all a dream. She pinched herself.

"Ow. Nope."

She turned to Ceria, who was pale-faced, clutching the burned spellbook in her hands. At Ksmvr, who was scratching at one of his antennae. At Yvlon, who was staring at where Teriarch had been, and at Pisces, standing forlornly in the snow.

In the end it was Termin who spoke. The older man sucked in his lips, and then shouted as loudly as he could.

"Who the hell was *that*?"

In his cave, Teriarch released the spell controlling his Human form at range and settled back into his cave. He created another image of the old man with the white beard and had it pick up the iPhone. The dragon hummed to himself as he flicked through the screens, staring at all the lovely new apps. He muttered to himself as he did.

"Is this what adventurers have sunk to? Ah, well. Perhaps they lied about being Silver-rank adventurers. And it was quite enjoyable to be out, although the outside was so busy...and the light was far too bright. Hmf."

He paused as a thought came to him. Erin Solstice. He'd only gone to her because Ryoka had been at Reinhart's estate and hard to reach without dealing with her at length. But she had recognized him and he, her. Where?

The Dragon's eyes widened.

"The girl."

For a brief second he considered sending himself out into the world again, to ask the girl how she'd found him. But then Teriarch hesitated, and

stared at the iPhone.

The outside was...the outside. He preferred his cave. And he had so much to entertain himself with now. Teriarch put Erin out of his thoughts and went back to tapping buttons on the iPhone.

“Now what’s this? Cookie Clicker?”

The Dragon stared at the screen as it changed colors. He frowned, pondered, and then began to tap.

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This is what she heard in the silence of the night.

[Tactician Level 16!]

[Conditions Met: Leader → Chieftain Class!]

[Chieftain Level 15!]

[Class Consolidation: Scavenger removed.]

[Class Consolidation: Tinkerer removed.]

[Skill – Tribe: Fleet Foot obtained!]

[Skill – Lesser Tinkering obtained!]

It was like thunder in her mind. The words thundered in Rags' head, waking her up instantly from her deep sleep. Unlike other times she'd leveled up, this announcement came towards the end of her rest. But once she had awoken, sleep was only a memory.

She had leveled up. Not only that, she had changed classes. She was a different person than she had been last night. Rags felt it. She was now a Chieftain, both among Goblins and in the eyes of the world.

Oh, sweetness. Rags made herself smile toothily as she sat up next to her personal campfire. She had been waiting a long time to hear those words.

In this world, leveling up was more important than a birthday. It was far more special than any holiday, and in fact constituted an occasion for rejoicing in itself. And so Rags told the rest of her tribe what had happened, knowing full well what would occur next.

A celebration.

Even Goblins partied, rare though such occasions were. It was a mark of a tribe's wealth that they could celebrate anything. As wrong as Tremborag's Goblins had been, they'd captured something in their huge banquets that represented Goblin society as a whole.

As dawn broke, the Flooded Waters tribe opened their stores of plundered food and piled wood on the embers of their fires. Goblins ran about, ate, drank what alcohol was available, had sex...

There really wasn't much to a Goblin party. But it was a time when they could all relax, except for those few unhappy souls who had to keep watch. Rags sat in the center of her camp, content to eat and do little else. That was what being a Goblin was like she reflected; a happy moment was one where you *didn't* have to do anything.

Of course, there was some attention paid to her as the center of this celebration. Rags was offered the choicest cut of meat and the best cooked food—although as Chieftain she generally got that anyways. She had her own seat which wasn't crowded and other Goblins made way for her—again, standard for any Chieftain. But it was enough and appropriate. The only other thing Goblins did was stare at Rags and pat her approvingly as she passed—that got annoying fast for her.

Tremborag's former Goblins were a bit more formal, however. Rags entertained several groups of Goblins who all congratulated her briefly and gave her small trinkets or choice bits of food. It was ceremony and she scowled at that, but made no comment.

It was just—Rags didn't feel that good. She sat next to Pyrite, letting him munch on the food she'd been given, trying not to glare as a group of Goblins ran past her, fighting over a large kebab one of the Goblins in front was trying to keep away from the others. She longed to shout at them to share and stop running in case one of the Goblins lost an eye on the poking stick—Goblin parties could have casualties if they got too wild—but she knew that would be pointless.

Rags felt bad and couldn't explain why. She knew there was reason to celebrate and liked the change in her class. It wasn't as if she was officially a Chieftain thanks to getting the class, but the Skills and title did help. It was a good thing.

She didn't feel happy, though. Accomplished—yes. Triumphant—yes. But happy?

No. Rags couldn't bring herself to smile and rejoice over it like the other Goblins. Not today. She just felt...

Tired. A bit tired, and almost melancholy, which was an odd emotion for a Goblin to have. But whatever feeling was in her, it overwhelmed whatever euphoria Rags should have had.

Why? Perhaps it was because for all this day was a triumph, it wasn't enough.

Creating crossbows, rebelling against Tremborag, learning how to use pikes, gaining the [Chieftain] class...today Rags could only think how small each of her accomplishments were. She stared moodily into the fire and didn't gorge herself.

And other Goblins noticed.

It was the consequence of being around so many people who knew you so well, from the way you walked to how you smiled and breathed. Rags could see Pyrite eyeing her as he sat and ate, and she had noticed how other Goblins looked at her before going back to celebrating. They knew their Chieftain was upset, even if they didn't know why.

But where Goblins differed from Humans and other species with similar characteristics was how they treated Rags. No Goblins went over to hug Rags or ask her how she felt. They left her alone to brood, and that made Rags feel better in itself. It was her problem, and Goblins didn't like to get involved in problems.

The party lasted for around three hours until it ended all at once. Goblins stopped eating, mainly because they were full, and the mood in the camp returned to normal in minutes. Sensing the change, Rags stood up and began to shout orders. It was time to get to work.

The first order of the day, which she'd been planning on without the addition of her [Chieftain] class, was testing out her tribe's warriors. Rags had a new tribe, forged out of many disparate groups. She had to know who she could trust to fight or go hunting, and who she had to keep an eye on and command directly.

So Rags organized a fight. Other races might have called it a sparring session, or a test of arms, or a mock battle. But Goblins knew a brawl when they saw one.

The rules were simple. Rags told all the Goblins to get rid of their armor, their weapons, and grab a stick or non-jagged rock. They formed into whatever groups suited them—some Goblins because they belonged to a group like the Redfang warriors, others because they were friends or family. Then Rags gave the command and all the various groups of Goblins ran at each other and started fighting.

It was *not* training. Training involved deliberately honing skills or practicing with weapons to become better in combat. Most Goblins didn't bother to train, although the Redfang warriors were an exception. But this was just a chance for Goblins to settle grudges without killing anyone and a chance for Rags to observe.

She sat on a tree stump as Pyrite sat next to her, chewing on some leftover gristle from the morning. She'd exempted him from the fighting and so he organized Goblins who dropped out of the brawl.

In this case dropping out meant the Goblins had had enough of being pounded on and walked away. Or they were carried if they'd been knocked out. Some of the pregnant female Goblins and younger ones—and ones not inclined to fighting—helped with this. The rest just hit each other.

Rags nodded to herself as she stared into the seething mass of green bodies. Her keen eyes could pick out individual Goblin's faces in the mass and so she saw what few others could.

The Redfang warriors were in the center of the battle, laying about with sticks and enjoying themselves immensely by the looks of it. They were easily dominating any other Goblins who came at them. However, they were outnumbered and so part of their group got split up. The Redfang warriors bashed their way through the Goblins, aiming for the edge of the fray where they could defend themselves more easily and wait to regroup with their friends.

Rags saw them reach another competent group of fighters. The all-female Goblin group was doing well against regular warriors, fighting with ferocity if not the same skill as the Redfang warriors. Rags paused though, as she saw a familiar head standing out among the rest of the Goblins.

The old Goblin. Rags frowned as she stared at the Goblin with the white beard who was happily tripping other Goblins up and kicking them while they were down. She'd told Pyrite to forbid Hobs from joining in the fight since they were too strong.

"Hey."

She reached over and poked Pyrite. He grunted—she'd gotten close to one of his potion-healed belly wounds. Rags glared at him and pointed at the old Goblin.

"Why he there? Hob."

"He is old. Doesn't fight fully."

That was all Pyrite said. It wasn't a full explanation, but Rags took it to mean Pyrite was looking out for Greybeard. She shrugged and watched his group. Her ears were good enough to hear him. He was pointing and talking to the female Goblin warrior who lead the group.

"Mm. Go this way, leader? Is good way."

Rags narrowed her eyes as the female Goblin warrior hesitated, and then led her Goblins left as the old Goblin had suggested. In the chaotic melee, her band of female Goblins somehow ended up in a perfect flanking position to the Redfang warriors. They helped another band of Goblins drub the elite Goblins until some more Redfang warriors ran into the backs of the Goblins and drove them apart.

That was odd. Had he known which way to go in that chaos? Or was it luck? For that matter, why did he belong with the female Goblins anyways? Rags knew he'd been in their faction in the mountain to survive, but it seemed odd their leader would accept his suggestions.

"He is smart."

Pyrite told Rags when she asked, and the female Goblin said the same thing as she and her warriors stumbled away from the battle.

"Crafty old one. Worth feeding."

That was that. Rags watched as the other Goblins kept fighting. It looked like the warriors from Tremborag's tribe who'd joined her were a bit above her regular warriors in skill, but only just. It still ended with a loss for every Goblin but the Redfang warriors, at least in the sense of who had the most bruises. But Rags was pleased to see Garen Redfang's best didn't get out completely unharmed.

That done, Rags let the Hobs do the same thing, only this time they had to fight completely unarmed and all the other Goblins watched. Pyrite declined to fight, but almost all the other Hobs were up for scrap. Rags watched them beat each other energetically and privately agreed with Pyrite's decision; the old Goblin would have gotten smushed battling these ones.

Hobs were strong. They had to be to be Hobs. Whether they were fat or thin, adept at long-ranged weapons or comfortable with a club, they were simply on a different level than normal Goblins. It bothered Rags a bit, as she watched them. Any one of these Hobs could kill her. If she had her crossbow and sword and shield she might have a chance, but if she missed

She was a bit weak, wasn't she?

Troubled, Rags watched the Hobs hit each other until they got bored. She let everyone break and eat lunch while she thought on her seat.

She now had a good idea who her best fighters and leaders were, and which units of Goblins excelled at what. So without further ado, Rags decided to divvy up Tremborag's cache of weapons and armor right then and there.

Her Goblins hadn't been idle testing out their new weapons. More than one sword had been blunted by hitting things, which was a pity, but a good whetstone would fix that. More importantly, Rags had an idea of which weapons were truly powerful.

There were only five. A wooden shield with faded paint showing some sort of flower on a field was unbreakable as far as her Goblins had been able to tell. They'd tried to burn it by dropping it in a campfire, had a Hob hit it, and let one of the felled trees drop on it. It didn't break.

Another sword shocked anyone that touched the blade, fairly badly. It wasn't a powerful enchantment per se, but it never *stopped* shocking and never ran out of magic. Any warrior with metal armor trying to block that would soon be numb.

A mace seemed to have the weight of a sledgehammer behind it. Another sword threw molten fire when you swung it hard—Rags eyed a badly burnt group of Goblins and decided not to give that one out. And one chest plate seemed to fracture any non-magical weapon that struck it, breaking the blades badly on impact.

Of course, there were plenty of other lesser magical artifacts. Some were sharper than they should be, others seemed unbreakable or burned or froze or in one case, made whatever they cut really itch. But the best artifacts were those five.

Rags was only slightly disappointed. She knew Tremborag had probably given the best artifacts out, but these were plenty good enough. They were of a higher quality than steel, which meant her warriors were outfitted as well as or better than most city militias. Even Liscor's City Watch didn't have magical weapons.

Dividing up the weapons among all of her eager warriors was a chore, though. Rags ended up giving both the shocking sword and the set of armor to Redscar, mainly because he was the highest-leveled warrior. He needed

good equipment and besides, none of the Hobs could wear the chest plate. It was big on Redscar, but he could wear it more or less easily.

She would have given the armor to Pyrite if she could. Rags offered him the mace instead, or the sword, but Pyrite declined both. He preferred his axe. So she gave him the shield and he seemed quite pleased.

The last mace went to one of Rags' Hobs, not one of the Redfang Warrior Hobs. This was purely to appease the Goblins who were upset the Redfang warriors got the bulk of the magical gear. Shields, high-quality armor, swords, and so on went to the delighted warriors. It made sense; they were Rags' best fighters, but the other Goblins were unhappy.

There were still factions. Or perhaps the Goblins would have been unhappy in any case, but Rags appeased them by making the Redfang warriors give up their original gear and share it with her other warriors. That way, they still received an upgrade in their equipment.

That done, Rags finally let herself have lunch. She took a block of cheese and melted it over some meat and slapped some bread on it and ate it messily by her fire. While she did, Rags gauged the mood of the camp.

The Goblins who'd been upset about not getting magical weapons... were only upset. They sulked for a few minutes and then brightened up at their shiny new steel ones. The Redfang warriors were happy, and Tremborag's former Goblins...

Seemed content. Some looked a bit disgruntled as they eyed the empty cart where only a few weapons remained—the molten fire sword and a shield that seemed to give any Goblin who held it a rash. Also, a spear that sprouted thorns everywhere except two specific handholds; none of the Goblins could remember where they were and kept getting their hands spiked. But Tremborag's Goblins understood that giving the weapons away was better than locking them up.

And Noears? Rags saw him eating happily and shooting lightning to impress a female Goblin—he hadn't cared about the weapons at all. Mages were like that.

Then Rags turned and saw the old Goblin. He was sitting next to Pyrite. Her eyes narrowed as she focused on him, the one oddity out of an otherwise predictable day.

He only acted stupid, Rags felt. She watched as he chattered to Pyrite, eating and laughing hugely as the other Hob ate in silence. That informed her next decision, much to the surprise of all Goblins.

Rags found that Goblins were best when they were led directly. Even under supervision, she required local group leaders to implement her orders. So she took her Hobs and divided them among her various groups. Some Hobs were in charge of leading hunting groups, others took over control of various warrior Groups.

A few Goblins were capable of leading too, of course. Redscar commanded the Redfang warriors as Rags' mobile attack force and vanguard. And the female Goblin warrior—Rags had learned her nickname was Poisonbite thanks to the two poisoned daggers she wielded—Rags put in command of another group.

Her tribe had order. It had leaders. But Rags felt she needed one last thing. She was restless. And after watching the brawl...angry for no reason she could explain. So after a brief consultation with Noears and Poisonbite she struck camp.

Goblins usually organized fast, but all of Rags' new policies and grouping caused delays. Still, it was best to iron out problems now and get her people used to the new system rather than later, so Rags gritted her teeth and dealt with the slow pace.

It was just hard to get everyone moving in the right formation. Rags wanted order when her tribe marched. Warriors would surround the noncombatants and valuable supplies and move in their units, rather than mix with non-warrior Goblins. It was a good idea, but hard to implement.

The new pikes proved to be another problem. The tribe had felled countless trees and fashioned hundreds of them, but they were just cumbersome to carry. They were obviously long and though they were actually lighter than they looked for being so tall—Rags guessed they were only around thirteen pounds in weight—they were still far heavier than a sword. Goblins had to work to carry them together, or if they were strapped to a wagon, they were so long they were in good danger of smacking Hobs or other obstacles as the wagons moved.

Rags sorted it out. Some Goblins could carry, and she had a few wagons modified to carry hundreds of pikes at one time. She yelled and bossed Goblins about and in the end she got her tribe moving.

They had to keep moving. It was just what Rags felt was right. She was missing something important. Their tribe finally set off, moving fast. Half again as fast as normal, in fact. To Rags' delight, her skill [Fleet Foot] made her tribe move across the snowy ground with ease. She immediately tried to

figure out how to use it to outmaneuver her enemies while marveling at how quickly her tribe could go.

And it meant they would definitely get where she wanted by tonight. Their destination was a well-known location to all of Tremborag's Goblins, an area relatively uninhabited by Human settlements. For good reason. When Rags had heard of this place—a small village—she'd immediately wanted to see it for herself.

All of Tremborag's former Goblins had objected, Poisonbite and Noears most stridently of all. But Rags had been adamant.

"Want to see."

That was all she told them, and Rags overruled all the objections. But she was lying and she knew it. Rags just wanted to kill something today.

On the march, Rags summoned Noears and made him tell her and Pyrite all he could about the surrounding area. He was happy to do it and Rags found she liked how intelligent he was and the breadth of his knowledge.

"Learned much while acting stupid, Chieftain."

He grinned at her and then pretended to be dumb, eyes losing focus, letting his mouth fall open as he drooled on himself. Pyrite grunted and grinned as he chewed on some frozen tree sap. Rags smiled despite her mood.

"Good. Other tribes?"

Noears nodded. He counted on his fingers, listing off several big Goblin tribes.

"Tremborag is biggest by far. But strong Chieftains live here."

"Have to be strong. Or run or die."

Pyrite added. Noears and Rags both nodded.

"Strong Chieftains. Not run. One—big Hob with tribe of many Hobs. Another—[Witch]. Knows fire magic. And a tribe with many thieves. Sneaks into places and steals..."

Rags listened, nodding appreciatively at the information. These tribes certainly were a cut above the ones around Liscor. She wondered if there were Goblin tribes in the south who were just as strong, besides the two she knew of. Had the Goblin Lord absorbed all of them into his army?

She was also curious about one of the Chieftains Noears had mentioned. A Chieftain who was also a [Witch]? Rags would love to meet her, but they were too far away. Going to visit their territory would mean a long journey,

Careful planning, scouting and fighting against monsters and Humans...and besides, after Tremborag, Rags was a bit tired of meeting new tribes.

That was how Rags occupied herself on the first part of the march. The second part as they crossed an open section of ground filled with untouched snow was devoted to fighting and avoiding monsters.

Golem!

The cry went up among the Goblins. Rags immediately kicked her Carn Wolf and shot forwards. She saw Redfang Warriors racing towards her waving their arms, at the same time she saw the Snow Golem.

It was...about the size of a hill. That was to say, it was around two hundred...two hundred and sixty feet high. And it was nearly as wide as it was tall. The massive abomination of snow *groaned*, the sound echoing for miles, the product of shifting tonnes of snow and dirt and rock.

Rags stared at the Snow Golem. It was no classic snowman built by Human kids anymore. It was more like a squat, vaguely pyramidal horror with long arms that scythed around aimlessly as it moved. Slowly.

It hadn't noticed the Flooded Waters tribe yet. Rags immediately shouted and her Goblins changed course, moving perpendicular to the Snow Golem to keep well away from it.

Snow Golems. Goblins knew countless monsters thanks to their tribal memory and experience living in the wilderness. But Snow Golems were usually one of the few monsters Goblins didn't fear. After all, a normal one wasn't that big unless the kids that made it were really ambitious and all they could do was smack you with their twig arms.

True, they could hit you hard enough to draw blood, but they were just *snow*. Hardly a threat unless they smothered you. Of the Golem species, Snow Golems were weaker than Mud Golems or Sand Golems, which was...embarrassing, really.

It was only when they got this big that Snow Golems got less funny. In the Winter, Snow Golems could get very big very fast, and hill-sized ones like these were to be avoided at all costs. So long as you kept your distance though, you were still pretty safe. All a Snow Golem could do at range was hurl part of itself at you. That was a concern with such a huge one, but they had terrible aim.

Giant Snow Golems weren't too dangerous...unless you happened to walk past one while it wasn't moving. Then the Snow Golem would grab you and swallow you whole. The stones, shards of ice, and crushing pressure of the Golem's body would grind you into paste quite quickly.

Oh, and cities, Rags supposed. If a Snow Golem found a city or village it would have to be slain quickly or lured away. Otherwise the city would be destroyed.

But all in all, it wasn't a threat. Rags was just relaxing as the Snow Golem became a distant mound slowly moving on the horizon when she heard another call go up.

"Attack! Monster!"

It was Noears who delivered this report. Rags turned left and saw something coming at her tribe through the snow, leaving a geyser in its wake.

Yes, most monsters usually fled a huge force of Goblins. No lone Mothbear would attack a vast tribe, even if it was starving. But some monsters could prey on Goblin tribes, attacking fast and taking away their victims. Other monsters were just insane.

Which kind was this? Rags couldn't see the monster amid the churning snow, but she shouted and the nearest group of warriors rushed forwards. They all had pikes she was glad to see, and they formed a wall, aimed at the approaching monster.

Rags waited, tense, astride her snarling wolf. More Goblins were rushing towards her, but they'd get here after the monster. She had to weather the first assault. And now, as the monster charged her Goblins, she saw what it was.

Half of a thing. At least, that's what Rags thought. The creature was dark green, skin full of crags. It looked...like half of a body. The upper half.

Huge, terribly long and powerful arms with massive claws that dragged it forwards. A torso of some dark green hide armored with what looked like scales of metal. But no lower half. And no head. Rags saw a gaping mouth where the neck should be, but no eyes.

It was some kind of horror, some monstrosity. Rags felt her Goblins shudder, but she shouted at them to hold position. There was no time to load her crossbow—Rags pointed at the thing and cast [Firefly].

The flaming insect-bird burned as it struck the monster, but the searing heat seemed to do nothing to the monster's thick hide. Rags pulled the gem

of [Terror] from her belt and held it up. Only briefly—it would affect her Goblin warriors too. But though they shuddered as the effects struck them, the crawling thing only dragged itself forwards again, ignoring the magic.

Hold ground!

Rags screamed it at her warriors, and then the crawling monster crashed into the rows of pikes. It didn't slow, and it didn't stop. Rags saw the wooden tips of the pikes breaking as they snapped under the monster's charge.

But some stuck into the creature. It jerked as two rammed deep into it, drawing viscous green blood. But it still kept coming.

Goblins screamed and the formation broke as the pikes failed. The crawling thing snatched up five Goblins and pressed them against its oval mouth full of teeth. Rags saw the Goblins screaming, flailing—then only blood.

“Chieftain!”

Lightning struck the crawler as it dropped the remains and crawled towards Rags. She pulled her mount back as Noears ran forwards and zapped the crawler. It didn't flinch as it kept coming.

“Redfang!”

Another cry. Redfang warriors on Carn Wolves sped forwards, slashing at the dark green hide of the crawler's back, drawing blood. But their weapons failed to cut deep as well, and the crawler swung at them, knocking one Goblin off his wolf.

“Surround! More pikes! Get Hobs!”

Rags screamed at her Goblins, trying to organize them. She brought every pike she could to bear on the thing—giving her Goblins a chance to hurt it as it charged them. She had crossbows pelting it, but still the crawler kept charging into the ranks of her warriors, heedless of the horrible injuries it was taking.

In the end, her Hobs had to wade in and bash it to death. The one with the mace managed to break something in one of the arms, and the others held the second down while Pyrite and the strongest Hobs beat at the thing. It took a long time to die.

When it was over, Rags counted the dead. Thirty five Goblins had died, eight of them Redfang warriors. She felt disgusted at herself and angry at

the thing—when Noears told her it was a good battle she nearly struck him.

“Killed too many!”

He just shrugged. He was sweaty from casting so many spells, but he looked better than her Hobs. All of them had taken wounds, especially the ones who’d had to hold down the thing’s good arm. Rags shouted at one to get a potion and the Hob gratefully went to get one from one of the wagons. She glared at Noears.

“What was?”

He shook his head as he stared at the dead green thing, lying in a puddle of its own gore in the stained snow.

“Crawler. Armored one.”

Rags eyed the dead monstrosity. None of the Goblins were willing to get near it, although a few with pikes kept poking it to make sure it wasn’t faking.

“What is?”

He didn’t know. Some kind of failed mage experiment maybe? Whatever the original had been, it had found a way to multiply over the years. It was just one monster among the ones around Invril, if a rare breed. The crawlers were suicidally aggressive. They’d attack anything edible, regardless of the danger. That they were still around was a testament to how hard they were to kill.

Rags stared at the dead Goblins, already going to a wagon to be chopped up later for food. She looked away.

She hadn’t participated in the battle. Oh, she’d organized her tribe, but Rags had only cast one spell. She’d had to lead, not fight. And her Goblins were dead because of it. It made Rags feel sick to her stomach, but she could only move on.

The Goblins left the crawler behind. None of them wanted to try eating it, and Rags wasn’t sure if it would be safe. She had the Goblins who’d gotten blood on them scrub the places clean with hot water, and then she marched on. They weren’t far from the village now.

It was late in the evening when Rags saw the village, a collection of rundown buildings in the snow, looking for all the world like an abandoned settlement.

She wasn’t fooled, though. As soon as she saw the village Rags immediately ordered all the non-warriors to pull back a few hundred feet

with a good-sized detachment of warriors to guard them. The rest of her warriors she took with her.

To battle.

The Goblins who lived in this part of the continent shuddered as they approached. They knew what this place was. The other Goblins picked up on the mood, but Rags kept them going.

And as they approached the village, the keen eyes of the Goblins began to pick out the inhabitants. The villagers wandered among the ruins of their home, shambling, ignoring the freezing snow.

Zombies.

It seemed like the light was darker around this place, or maybe the sun was just setting more quickly. But this was a famous spot. A village of the dead. A place where the dead could not die.

Zombie villages weren't unheard of. If a horde killed off an entire village, they could soon all become shambling undead creatures. But this one was...unique. Because these zombies didn't move from this village. They guarded their former home in death as they had in life.

No one knew why. But though adventuring teams had been sent and monsters had clashed with the undead, no one had been able to raze the village once and for all. There were simply too many zombies. With each death, a new one rose to join their ranks so that this village was small, but Rags knew hundreds or more than a thousand zombies had to be hiding in the snow, or in the houses.

No one came here. There was too much death. Overwhelming death. That was the consensus among Goblins and Humans, it seemed. This village of the dead was a beehive waiting to be disturbed. And once it was, it would consume whomever was foolish enough to trespass here.

But Rags wanted a fight. She had her sword and buckler out and she was leading her Goblins herself—against her commander's objections. Pyrite was walking next to her, axe on his shoulder. He'd only nodded when she said she wanted to test her forces against this village.

Rags called a halt as she saw the zombies take notice of her warriors. She began organizing them, putting pikes out front, having her crossbows move to the center while she pulled the wolf riders back for quick attacks. She was going to attack this army of the dead with her new formation and see how well it held up.

It felt wrong to make her Goblins fight after the crawling thing, but Rags had decided to do it anyways. The way they'd broken when it had gotten past the pikes proved that she needed to drill them, to make them into a unified fighting force.

The zombies came in a shambling mass. They didn't run, but they moved faster than Rags would have liked. She eyed them, watching for the telltale sign of Ghouls or other undead stalking along the mass of zombies, but found none around the outskirts of the village.

More were rising from the snow. Rags looked at her Goblin warriors. She had a good box formation—a phalanx if Rags had known the word—going on. But she didn't want to remain stationary.

“Pikes!”

They stiffened as Rags raised her voice. The Goblin warriors holding the pikes were not elites. They didn't like being in front without Hobs, but Rags wanted to prove to them her new tactics *would* work. She shouted at them and they tensed, leveling their spears at the sea of dead bodies coming at them.

“Charge!”

Rags pointed her sword and the Goblins around her ran forwards, screaming in both fear and rage. She ran too.

The pike Goblins hit the zombies *hard*. Rags saw bodies being impaled on the spears, and those that survived ran into the Goblins in the formation with swords who hacked at them. Rags shouted, and the pikes fought for a few seconds before attempting to disengage.

It was hard. She ran forwards, cutting and found Pyrite and other Goblin warriors were at her side. They forced the zombies back and the Goblins ran, some abandoning their pikes despite Rags shouting.

Rags thrust her short sword into a zombie's head and watched as it fell. But only seconds after it had fallen she saw it trying to get back up. She cursed. This wasn't what she'd thought would happen at all!

This village of the dead refused to die. Zombies came back to life...in a manner of speaking. When killed, they would reattach their severed limbs, regenerate burned skin. Rags had heard it was possible to kill them by disintegrating them or chopping them up into really small bits, but it was hard to do that when countless more of them were attacking you.

She'd thought it would be a good group to test her warriors on. But these zombies came back to life *fast*. Rags burned the corpse with [Firefly]

and shouted at her warriors to retreat.

They did so, the Hobs moving back last. They were far stronger than zombies and easily cut the dead apart. But they kept coming back.

This truly was a village that no one could use. Necromancers couldn't control these strange zombies, and it was pointless to try and eradicate the bodies. They just kept reforming, making the dead villagers and victims over the years into a truly immortal force. And if it were just zombies it would be fine. However...

"Ghouls!"

Rags heard the cry go out. She looked over and saw Poisonbite shouting. Crossbows loosed and Rags saw darting shapes streaming out of the village stumbling, but more came on. She shouted and the Goblins around her started running in a true retreat.

"Chieftain!"

Rags heard Pyrite and turned to see a Ghoul leaping at her from the left. She cut at it and dodged it. The Ghoul landed, one arm dangling uselessly. Rags stabbed at it. She got it in the throat, but the Ghoul just impaled itself further on her blade as it rushed at her. Rags bashed it with her buckler, but the Ghoul cut her. It ripped at the leather armor on her stomach and Rags gasped as she felt something slice her belly. Then it struck her on the head and the world went dark.

"Chieftain!"

Something *shook* the ground around Rags. She stumbled, flailing with the buckler but the Ghoul was gone. Rags fell back. So. She couldn't kill one Ghoul? She really was...

She felt someone pulling her back. Away...

When Rags woke up, her tribe was marching quickly. She sat up groggily, but it was dark. She realized they were marching away from the village and dropped her head back to whatever she was lying on.

Rags slept.

When he was young, the Goblin King often caught the many varieties of insects in his jungle home. He would study each one he caught before eating them. Some were brightly colored beetles, others worms with wings,

or biting insects made far too large. Many were poisonous and kept him sick. Others were actually tasty, or had beneficial effects.

The Goblin King learned which were good and taught his friends and tribe. So it was that he became a [Healer] long before he became a Chieftain of his tribe. And he never forgot, even when his [Healer] class was merged into his [Chieftain] class...

Rags sat up. She covered her aching head in her hands and then realized she was healed. She was healed—

And she was in camp. It was late at night, very late. Goblins were camped...where? Rags looked around.

They were sitting in the middle of the snowy plains. Far, a few miles away from the village. Far enough that Pyrite must have decided they were safe. He'd saved her.

Rags remembered what had happened in jolts as she struggled to her feet. She felt tired—weak. And ashamed.

“Chieftain.”

Someone came towards her. A huge shape. Pyrite. He saw Rags was up and immediately called out. A Goblin ran over with hot meat on a stick. Rags tore at it greedily as Pyrite led her to a fire where the ground had been cleared to sit.

Goblins were lying or sitting in small groups in the cold night. Many of them glanced up as Rags passed by and then looked down. She couldn't meet their eyes and the food in her hands cooled as she lost her appetite.

“Eat. Sit.”

Pyrite sat Rags down. She found herself sitting at a small fire with the Hob and one other Goblin. Greybeard smiled at Rags as he chewed on some tough meat.

There was something in Rags' eyes. It made her stare at the fire and it was in Pyrite's gaze and Greybeard's as well. Not reproach; that would have been easier.

“How many dead?”

That was all Rags asked. Pyrite thought.

“Less than a hundred.”

He didn't lie, but Rags didn't want to know how many less than a hundred really was. Ninety nine? She stared into the fire.

“My fault.”

None of the Goblins around her replied. They knew it was true. Rags had made a mistake. She'd taken her Goblins here to fight—because she'd wanted to fight. She'd wanted to prove she was a good warrior and a Chieftain. All she'd done was get Goblins killed.

“Chieftain wants to be a warrior. Is not one.”

Greybeard cackled and Pyrite poked him hard, making the older Goblin yelp. Rags said nothing. She bowed her head.

A bit of envy. A bit of frustration. She did want to be a better warrior than she was. She liked being a Chieftain, but it hadn't been enough, had it? So she'd killed over a hundred Goblins today with her pride.

It was painful. And yet Rags still felt the same desire in her chest. The urge.

“Too weak. I am weak.”

She looked at Pyrite. He paused, and nodded.

“Best leader is smart. But strong is also good.”

“I must be strong.”

Greybeard nodded. Pyrite nodded. Rags knew the Goblins pretending to slumber around her agreed. A Chieftain could be cunning, but she had to be strong enough too. Strong with her head, strong with her body—Rags desired both.

“Tell me about the Goblin King.”

Rags said it suddenly. She looked at Greybeard and the old Goblin froze. Pyrite looked at Rags.

“Long time ago.”

“Yes.”

Long for a Goblin. But not for a Human. Many had been alive when the last Goblin King had, and Tremborag had fought with him. Surely this old Goblin knew the King. Rags remembered the Goblin King as a small Goblin, foraging in a jungle and was suddenly consumed by curiosity.

“Who was he? Why did he kill? What does it mean to be Goblin?”

The Goblins fell silent. What few that had been eating paused, and Rags knew that they weren't pretending to look away. All eyes turned to Greybeard.

And he—lost his usual grin. He stopped eating and stared into the fire. And when he spoke, his voice was deeper. It wasn't crackling and merry, but somber. Quiet.

“The Goblin King was a peaceful king for many years. Six years he ruled and we lived without fighting.”

Rags stared at him. She had never known that.

“Without?”

“Without.”

Greybeard tossed an unchewed bone into the fire and watched it *crack*.

“We made peace with the Humans, Gnolls, even Drakes. On this continent. On Baleros we forged alliances. While he lived, Goblins were only hunted in a few places, and most of us prospered.”

He only acted stupid. Rags stared at the old Hobgoblin and looked at Pyrite. He looked at her, calm and unsurprised. He knew Greybeard was smart. How?

“You remember?”

Rags saw Greybeard turn. His face was caught by the dim firelight and she saw a younger Goblin there. How old did you have to be to have your hair turn white? He grinned at her, exposing his remaining yellow teeth.

“Know him? I saw him die. I was there. I remember the Goblin King, Velan. And as the Humans and other races named him: Velan the Kind. And I remember the King before that. Curulac of a Hundred Days.”

Silence. Perfect, so quiet you could hear the snow fall. No Goblin here had known the last Goblin King. And Rags had never known the one before him.

Curulac. Who had he been? The oldest memory she had experienced hadn’t hinted of him. She could only look back to the Goblin King’s youth now.

“What were they like?”

Greybeard paused. Then he pointed up and smiled.

“Like stars.”

Rags looked up at the night sky. She stared as some clouds shifted and the stars emerged. She understood. Distant, radiant things, untouchable. Unreachable.

“How can I become a better Chieftain?”

“Learn.”

That was all Greybeard said. Pyrite stared at Rags and shrugged. He fished the bone out of the fire, cooled it in some snow, and began to chew it to bits.

Rags got up and walked away from the fire. She walked around her camp once, twice. She checked on the wounded, but Pyrite had given potions to those that needed it. She watched the sun rise, and then found the Redfang warriors.

They were quiet too from last night's battle. But few of them had died, and they were already beginning to train as the sun slowly rose. Rags stopped before Redscar with her buckler and sword. He was doing pushups. He paused, and then turned his head sideways as Rags got down on the ground and copied him.

"Chieftain. Bad form."

"How?"

"Like this."

He corrected her arms, made her place her hands wider, straighten her back. Rags grunted as she struggled to hold that position. She was fit, but not like he was. After a while her arms began to hurt, but she kept lowering herself to the ground and lifting herself up slowly.

"Good. Slow. Do twenty more."

Redscar supervised her as Rags did more pushups, determined not to cry out. She knew other Redfang warriors were watching her. When she was done, she was sweating with exhaustion in the cold.

"What now?"

"Now—other exercises. Want to try?"

"Yes."

Rags followed Redscar as he performed various stretches and moves which made her muscles burn. When he was done Rags felt as if she'd never been more tired. She hadn't known just doing things like lifting her legs over her head could get so *tiring*.

"Chieftain is not bad."

Redscar grinned at Rags. He had a sword in his hand. She eyed it as she sat up.

"What now?"

"Now? Sparring unless moving."

Rags made a face. She hated sparring. She'd done it with Garen and leveled up, but only a bit. She pointed at the other Redfang warriors. They were locking blades, letting each other parry blows, strike at each other. When they were actually intending to hit each other they used dull, wood weapons.

“Does it work?”

“Works. You will level.”

“Haven’t much.”

Rags caught a tossed practice sword and hopped back as Redscar slashed at her. She held her buckler up and jabbed at him, keeping him away. He slid forwards and nearly broke her guard with a heavy blow.

“Garen Redfang only beat you up. Training means winning too.”

Pyrite and Greybeard found Rags training with another Redfang warrior as the rest of the Goblins finished packing up the camp. Rags was exhausted. She’d lost to Redscar every time they’d sparred, but won twice against some of the weaker Redfang warriors.

Greybeard cackled as he saw Rags bash a Redfang warrior in the head and then poke him hard in the gut with her wooden sword.

“Hah! Chieftain is strong! For Goblin.”

“Not for Hob.”

“True.”

Redscar watched approvingly from the side. He and the other Redfang warriors had observed Rags’ progress and she felt they were more accepting of her than they had been. She wasn’t nearly as good as they were, but she had kept up with them.

“Will train every day?”

Pyrite glanced at one of the Redfang Hobs who was dueling four Goblins at once. Rags nodded. She saw Poisonbite and Noears had come by as well. Poisonbite was watching some of the male Redfang warriors who’d stripped down to almost nothing with interest. Noears was watching the female ones with interest.

“Will train. Pyrite, you will too. All warriors will.”

“Yes, Chieftain.”

Rags nodded appreciatively at him, but Poisonbite scowled. She folded her arms, looking unhappy at the idea of that kind of exercise.

“Goblins do not train.”

Rubbing her sore arms, Rags eyed her. Poisonbite was one of the typical Goblin warriors. She liked fighting, but didn’t like practicing fighting. You either fought or rested. She answered the female Goblin shortly.

“My Goblins will.”

“Is it Goblin?”

The challenge came as Rags was picking up her short sword. Rags whirled, fury in her eyes. It wasn't a direct attack, but it was as close as any Goblin had come. Poisonbite flinched a bit, but she didn't back down from Rags.

"It is Goblin. Goblins must be strong."

"Training is not Goblin."

Poisonbite didn't quite dare meet Rags' eyes. Rags hissed. Why were Goblins like Poisonbite so *small*? So...?

She had her sword in one hand. Rags longed to raise it, but someone hurried in front of her. Greybeard. He had a bowl of soup in his hands and cackled at her in that deceptive tone of his.

"No angry, Chieftain. Calm, yes. Eat food. Is tasty. Eat."

She stared at him. Two innocent eyes stared back. Greybeard was pretending to be...senile again. With a noise of disgust Rags seized the bowl. She found she did feel better after a few mouthfuls of food, but she still eyed Poisonbite angrily.

"Did the Goblin Kings do that?"

"Do what, Chieftain?"

Greybeard stared at Rags innocently. She stared back.

"Did they do it? Train?"

"If they did, it was Goblin."

It was a non-answer. Rags made a noise of disgust and hurled the empty bowl at Greybeard. He caught it and cackled.

"Training is good! Makes Goblins strong! If Chieftain says so, is it not Goblin?"

"It is good. And it will make Goblins live."

That was all Rags said. She stared at Poisonbite—the other Goblins refused to meet her eyes. But Noears calmly nodded.

"Yes Chieftain."

That would have to do. Rags nodded. But Redscar intercepted her as she went back for a second helping of food.

"Chieftain. Where now?"

Rags stared at him blankly. Then she remembered. They were camped out here, with provisions depleting with each meal. What should they do now?

She only had a vague idea. Rags hesitated, then pointed south.

"Go home. Fight Goblin Lord. Make base."

Redscar nodded.

“Old Redfang base? Good. Defensive.”

“Maybe.”

Rags pondered. She was more concerned about the immediate march.

“Must hunt. Get food. Also—Humans.”

The Goblin bared his teeth, making the scar on his face twist.

“Lots of Humans, Chieftain. To kill?”

Rags hesitated. That certainly seemed to be their only choice. But...

Too weak. Rags felt the same pang in her chest. How could she lead her tribe when she couldn't be fighting in the front? No—how could she order them to fight Human adventurers, who might kill hundreds of them?

She was not Tremborag. But she was a Chieftain now. She had the class. Rags felt it. The thing she'd felt since waking yesterday.

Pressure. And a bit of fear that she wasn't good enough.

But she was Chieftain. Rags squared her shoulders and stood tall. She looked down at Redscar, though he was physically taller than she was. But Rags stood ten feet tall. She was a Chieftain. And inspiration flickered in her mind as she stared across her vast tribe, thousands strong now.

“We will go south. And Humans? I will beat them all.”

“You, Chieftain? How?”

“With head. Not arm.”

Redscar stared at her. Then, he smiled.

“Good. That is why we follow you.”

Rags grinned in reply.

It was a large adventuring group that found the Furgather Tribe in their home. Over forty Bronze-rank adventurers and six Silver-rank adventurers attacked the tribe's camp at midday. They slew the Chieftain and fought the Hobs with overwhelming numbers while the others held the Goblins at bay.

They had come to wipe out the tribe. The Goblins were pressed up against a cliff wall, unable to escape. Old Goblins and children fled the adventurers with blades, who cut down all Goblins without distinction. If some hesitated when they saw the infants, well, they were new. The Silver-rank ones had taken more than one extermination request.

The Furgather tribe wasn't a strong one. They had preyed on villages, stolen rather than killed. They were weak, the weakest of monsters in a place where only the strong survived. Now, the remaining Goblins cried out as they formed an ever-shrinking core, trying to defend their friends and families.

They cried out for someone to save them, knowing that no one would come. Knowing there were no gods, and certainly none for Goblins. But someone did hear them.

A wolf howled. The adventurers heard the sound and some turned to look. They saw a wolf sitting on a distant hill. One of the adventurers with [Keen Eyes] cried out and pointed.

“Mounted Goblin!”

There was indeed a Goblin mounted on the back of the Carn Wolf. She had a crossbow in her hands and she was aiming it at the adventurers. Instantly, they turned—ten Bronze rank adventurers keeping the remaining Furgather Goblins pinned while the rest spread out. Where there was one Goblin, they knew there would be more.

But they were not prepared for the army that came over the hill. Goblins, a huge mass of them, flooded over the hill. Not just any wild Goblins either; the adventurers saw a row of pikes forming a wall aimed at them, while the rest took positions behind them.

Thousands of Goblins. Some sat on the backs of huge red wolves, others were the dreaded Hob variants, tall as any Human and far stronger than most. And the Goblins standing on the hill all had crossbows trained on the adventurers.

They had height, numbers, and everything else on their side. The adventurers froze with fear. They saw huge Hobs, a match for any Silver-rank adventurer, among the Goblins' number.

They were going to die.

But the Goblins didn't attack. They held position, waiting. And then the Goblin the adventurers had first seen rode slowly towards the tribe. She was small. Young. But she was their Chieftain.

And she saw what the adventurers had done. The Goblin looked at the dead bodies of the Furgather tribe's warriors and sighed. Then she looked at the adventurers. There was something cold in her eyes. But all she said to them were two things.

“Drop weapons.”

The adventurers stared at her. Rags pointed at one of them—a Silver-rank [Ranger] with a bow.

“Drop. Or die.”

She hesitated. The other adventurers waited for her cue. Did they fight and surely die, or surrender and...? They knew what Goblins did to women.

The [Ranger] chose to fight. She swung her bow up, but lightning struck her and eight arrows struck her before she could draw the arrow in her bow. She fell, and the other adventurers cried out—eight arrows had struck the [Ranger], but stray shots had landed among them.

“Surrender.”

That was all the small Goblin said. The adventurers threw down their weapons, realizing they had no chance. The Furgather Goblins rushed forwards, crying out with rage, but the Goblin on the wolf shouted something at them in their own language.

It was a strange group of forty nearly naked adventurers who ran from the place where the Furgather Goblins had lived. Their armor was gone, as were their weapons. But they were alive, which was more than could be said for many of the Furgather tribe. They sat, mourning their dead as some were made into food.

Rags found one of the Goblins who might be in charge. He stared up at her, afraid of her Carn Wolf and her strange tribe. She nodded to him.

I am Rags. Flooded Waters Chieftain.

He gabbled his thanks at her. Rags cut him off. She pointed at his tribe.

“Can rebuild. Or follow.”

Then she turned and rode away. Her tribe followed. The Furgather Goblin stared at her back for a second, and then called out. His Goblins followed Rags’ tribe.

An hour later, a large caravan moved down the road, headed towards the city of Ostegrast. It was a large caravan as they went. Over thirty laden wagons rumbled down the road, protected by a force of nearly a hundred [Guards] and [Mercenaries]. Around these lands, there was safety in such numbers. The [Traders] and [Merchants] in the convoy sat comfortably on

their mounts, secure in the knowledge that few monsters would dare attack them.

But then they heard the drumbeats. At first, it was just an odd sound that made some of the Humans pick at their ears, wondering if they were hearing things. But then they heard the sound grow louder, and knew it was no illusion.

“An army?”

The [Merchant] in charge of the caravan rode up beside the [Mercenary Captain], a tall man who used a broadsword and shield. The man frowned as he looked towards the horizon.

“I haven’t heard of one. And they wouldn’t be beating the drums. There’s no war going on!”

“Then what—”

The question went unasked. The drums suddenly grew louder, and more sounded from the opposite direction of the caravan. It slowed as all of those riding had a terrible premonition.

“Can we get off the road?”

“Too late.”

The mercenary drew his sword and shouted orders. The caravan moved into a circular formation and the guards spread out to guard their charges. And all the while the heavy beats grew louder and louder.

The drums thundered. They sounded more like crashing metal than a conventional drum. The rhythmic thumping went through the bones of the Humans who stared around in fear.

Then they saw the Goblins. Hundreds of them. Thousands. They seemed to appear from nowhere out of the snow. And indeed—some of them were sitting up and brushing snow off of their bodies. They had been lying there, waiting for the caravan.

It was a trap! The [Guards] closed ranks around the frightened [Merchants] and [Traders]. They held their weapons up as an act of defiance more than anything else; against so many Goblins and surrounded as they were, there was no hope of survival.

A Goblin rode forwards. Rags had the gem of [Terror] in one hand, but she didn’t want to use it. She wanted those horses and the cargo—intact.

The Humans were waiting for death, but they weren’t prepared for the Goblins on the other side of the road to part ranks. They stared as the opening formed and at Rags with suspicion and fear.

“Leave wagons. Run. Live.”

Rags grinned at them, her black crossbow resting on her Carn Wolf’s head, much to the beast’s annoyance. The Humans hesitated.

Goblins? Acting like bandits? It was unheard of. Goblins would rather just slaughter all of them, surely. But this Goblin was giving them a way out.

The mercenary captain was first to move. He cautiously called out, and his soldiers shuffled towards the gap. The [Merchants] and [Traders] shouted at them to stay, but no one in the convoy was going to die for nothing. Soon, all the Humans were standing away from the wagons. They stared at Rags, as if afraid she was going to order her Goblins to attack now.

“We can leave? You swear it?”

One of the Humans called out uncertainly. Rags rolled her eyes she waved her hands.

“Shoo. Go away.”

She gestured, and the Humans slowly backed away towards freedom. Only when they were past the last Goblins and dared to race away on their horses did Rags signal her Goblins to move in.

The cargo was full of food and other goods, a bountiful shipment meant to keep the Human city well supplied and make the [Merchants] and [Traders] rich. Rags grinned as she and Pyrite inspected the boxes.

“Lots of horses.”

She liked horses. They were good at pulling things and tasty, too. Pyrite was also smiling. There was some dried jerky in the crates that he was already tasting.

“Do again?”

Rags nodded. She figured she had one day before word got out. Goblins raiding the roads was bad for business, and surely an army would be sent to destroy them. But by that point she’d be going south, to war with the Goblin Lord.

And perhaps...perhaps the army sent would be slower than most. Because Rags had only killed five Humans today. Only the ones who would rather die than give up their goods or throw down their weapons.

It wasn’t perfect, but it was her plan. Goblins could be like bandits, who were more like people than Goblins. And she could win battles with her head and without losing a single Goblin, which was better than them dying.

She smiled at Pyrite. He chewed some jerky and offered her some. She waved it away.

“Is this good Chieftain thing?”

He shrugged.

“Scare the Humans. Good plan. Is fun.”

Rags nodded. She stared towards the sky. It was daytime, so the stars weren't visible. But she wondered if the Goblin King had been like this. Once upon a time. Had he wondered if what he was doing was right? Had he made so many bad mistakes?

She didn't know. Rags could only trust herself. So she called out and her Goblins cleared the road. They could raid one more caravan. Then they'd be heading south. Towards Liscor. Towards war and death, Rags knew. But also to a small inn she'd missed. And an innkeeper that Rags wanted to speak with, to talk with. To ask her questions and hear her reply.

South.

Back home.

Wistram Days (Pt.1)

“You have been accepted to Wistram Academy. Present yourself on the docks in South Harbor, Belan, Terandria two weeks from now. Do not be late.”

Ceria Springwalker still remembered the words the examiner had spoken to her. And now here she sat, on the salt-crusted docks in South Harbor, in the city of Belan, one of the southern port-cities on the continent of Terandria. She was not late.

Still, the half-Elf could not help but look around nervously now and then. She had no idea what to expect, but she only knew that she'd been waiting for this day for over forty years and she was terrified of making a mistake.

She was 58 years old, and while that was quite a lot of years for a Human, Ceria was still considered a young adult by her people. But she was old enough to be independent and so there was no one to see her off.

The same could not be said of the other people gathered on the docks. It was an odd assortment. Ordinary citizens, respectably dressed, stood next to men and women dressed in expensive clothing that practically reeked of the aristocracy. In point of fact, neither group stood *next* to one another—there was usually a well-dressed manservant in the way.

But it was here that the rich and poor had come alike, to see their family and friends off. This was the one day in the year when the isle of Wistram opened, and they accepted new students.

Ceria's palms were sweaty. She wiped them on her trousers and hoped no one would notice. Already she was attracting some attention. It was rare for a prospective student to be alone, especially given the entrance fee.

Twenty gold pieces. That was the price for attending Wistram Academy for a month. It was a ridiculous sum, and Ceria had spent the best part of a decade saving enough money to afford the cost. But it had been worth it. Would be worth it.

She knew other families probably didn't have that much money. The nobles and merchants, yes, but the other families had to have sold off

heirlooms or borrowed heavily to meet the cost. But assuming they had that much money, anyone could enter Wistram.

Anyone with magic, that was.

Ceria had proven her abilities by showing the examiner a few of the spells she'd taught herself. [Stone Dart], [Flame Jet]—and of course, the spell that had saved her life many times. [Chameleon].

They weren't high-Tier spells. In fact, all of these spells were barely Tier 2. But it was powerful magic for someone who'd never had the luxury of owning a spellbook, and that, added to the steep entrance fee, had bought Ceria a place on the ship.

It was a tall vessel, the *Errant Traveller*. Two massive sails stood furled as the ship floated in its berth. Ceria had already noticed the sailors and [Captain] bustling around the ship, so she predicted they'd be underway soon enough.

"Are they about to set sail?"

Ceria's pointed ears perked up as she heard a young man—no, a boy, really—talking excitedly to his parents. He was with a family seeing off a woman – a merchant's daughter by the looks of her – as they excitedly scrutinized the ship. The young boy tugged harder at his mother's hand.

"Can I go too? How will they get there? Is the ship magic, too?"

"Hush. Let your sister say her goodbyes in peace. And who knows whether the ship is magical? When you're a [Mage], I expect all sorts of wondrous things are possible."

Ceria had to smirk at that, although she turned away so no one would notice. Magic ships? Maybe if they were enchanted, but she very much doubted this one was. The family seemed to think this was some special ship, but it was just an ordinary vessel to Ceria's eye.

After all, students from around the world would be making the journey to Wistram this day. Rather than keep a fleet of their own, the mages doubtless found it easier to simply hire ship captains to transport students for them.

And as if her thoughts had summoned him, suddenly the [Captain] was striding down the gangway, speaking loudly.

"The *Errant Traveller* is ready to go! All students are to come aboard one at a time. Tell me your names and I shall cross you off the list!"

The people on the docks stirred. Several young men and women darted towards the gangway as if being last meant you wouldn't be allowed on

board. Ceria saw last goodbyes hurriedly exchanged as she stood up.

A long queue of bodies was already stretching down the dock by the time Ceria joined the line. She saw only Humans standing behind each other. Quietly, Ceria took her place behind a young man in expensive clothes, trying to ignore the looks the other people gave her.

The line moved forwards slowly, but Ceria passed the time thinking of what would happen next. The journey by boat would take several days assuming the weather held. And when they reached the isle, she'd probably have to wait through an introduction. After that she had just over a month to prove herself and be accepted—

Or sent home.

"Next!"

Ceria walked forwards and realized she was standing at the entrance to the ship. The Captain stared down at Ceria. His eyes flicked to her ears, but he made no comment.

"Name?"

"Ceria Springwalker."

"Yes, I see your name on the list. Go on and find a place down below. Cause no trouble and cast no magic while you are on my ship."

Was that last line for her? But Ceria dimly recalled the others being told the same. She nodded and stepped onto the deck of the ship. It took her a few seconds to get used to the gentle rocking of the boat and then she was fine.

Glancing around, Ceria saw some of the new students stumbling around, much to the amusement of the sailors watching them. She glanced over her shoulder and saw only ten or so more people waiting in line. The Captain was slowly running his finger down the list as he stared at a scrawny young man dressed in shabby clothes.

A list? Was that all he was using, people's names on a piece of paper? What if Ceria had claimed to be someone else? Was it really that easy to steal a spot on board?

Most [Captains] could read well, but Ceria was still surprised that anyone would use such an uncertain system. Then, as she passed by the Captain she saw that he was holding a piece of paper with her face printed on it. It was so lifelike Ceria nearly gasped, but as the Captain went down the list the paper changed, showing the face of the next student attempting to board.

Magic.

She grinned and walked below decks. The sudden darkness was a stark change, but light shone through port holes. And as Ceria's eyes adjusted she saw that this ship was well-equipped for transporting so many people. Instead of the hammocks sailors used, small cots had been set up with pillows and blankets to make sleeping on the hard wood easier.

Most of the new students had congregated near the center and already chosen a spot. Ceria looked around for somewhere secluded. Her arrival had not gone unnoticed though, and the eager group of young men and women turned to look at her.

That's when the whispers started. Ceria had expected it, but it still made her stomach clench. The people who had noticed her pointed and exclaimed, and then began to talk amongst each other.

"Hey. Is that...?"

"No. Really?"

"I think it is. One of them."

"Ugh. They let *that* apply?"

"Half-Elf."

It was a word spoken like a curse. Ceria ignored the voices and dumped her belongings in a corner of the ship. The young woman who'd chosen a place three spots over stared at her in disgust and moved away. Ceria stared out one of the portholes, keeping her face calm and blank.

Half-Elf. That was what she was, and that was the reason for the distrust from the other Humans. The reputation of half-Elves was well known on Terandria. They were untrustworthy, thieves, criminals and bandits at the best of times. They lied, cast harmful magics, preyed on good, innocent folk, and they stole children out of cradles at night.

In truth, everyone knew that last claim was false. Most half-Elves wanted as little to do with Humans as possible, and no one wanted to raise a stinking Human brat. Half-Elves kept to their own communities, on the edges of society, and they were tolerated because they were useful and some half-Elves had valuable Skills or high levels. But they were not liked.

On this continent, at least. Ceria sighed as the whispering subsided. Terandria was not kind to most non-human species, on a continent where the populace was overwhelmingly Human. Maybe another continent—Izril or Baleros, perhaps—would be different where Humans were just one species among many.

But it seemed that while these Humans were prepared to leave behind their home and families to learn magic, they still brought their hatreds with them. Ceria only hoped Wistram would be more open to her.

It was hard to hide being a half-Elf, anyways. Ceria knew her unearthly complexion stood out even in a crowd, and besides that, she had pointed ears. It was almost as bad as having a scar on your forehead to point you out and it had already ostracized her from the others in the hold.

“Ah, hello? Is this seat taken?”

Startled, Ceria looked up. She’d already begun organizing her small pack so she’d be sleeping with it to her back in case someone tried to steal from her. She looked up and saw a young man’s face, a nervous smile, and a shock of brown hair. It was the smile that surprised Ceria the most.

“Is this seat taken? I don’t believe it is, but I would like to check before putting my belongings down here.”

The young man repeated the question. Ceria blinked at him and then found her voice.

“What? No, it’s not. But uh, do you—”

Too late. The young man was already dumping his rucksack on the ground. Ceria eyed his belongings skeptically. She’d thought she had brought only the bare minimum, but this young man only had a few changes of clothes, a small bar of lye soap, a toothbrush, and—

A rapier.

Ceria blinked. It had a long leather sheath, but it was unmistakably a rapier just from the hand guard and grip that stuck out at the top. She’d never seen any warrior using a rapier—it was the weapon of [Lords] and the aristocracy. What was a boy like this doing with one?

And he was a boy. Oh, he might have been closer to sixteen or seventeen, but to Ceria this young man and most of the passengers below decks were children. Only a few men and women were among students and they kept to themselves.

“Are you sure you want to sleep here?”

Ceria had to raise her voice to make herself heard. All of the students were below decks now, and their voices were overlapping with the shouting of sailors above and the *creak* of the ship.

The young man looked startled at being addressed. He nearly dropped his rapier and brushed hair out of his eyes.

“Well, yes, I mean, I do apologize if I’ve disturbed you. It’s just that I saw this spot was open and I thought I could take it. If you want to be left alone I can—”

He looked around wildly, but almost all of the other beds were taken.

“Stop that. I meant, are you okay with having me as a neighbor?”

“You? Why would I—”

The young man’s eyes widened as he looked at Ceria’s face and he saw her ears. She sighed internally and waited for him to exclaim in disgust.

“Are you a *half-Elf*? My word, I’ve never—may I shake your hand? I’ve never met one of your kind before. I’m delighted to meet you! My name is Pisces!”

Ceria blinked as she found a hand in front of her face. She took it uncertainly and felt her hand being shaken rapidly.

“I’m uh, Ceria. Ceria Springwalker.”

Pisces beamed at Ceria as he sat next to her. As the ship began to move he began chattering and Ceria, almost unconsciously, began replying.

“I must confess, I was quite alarmed when I found a mostly Human crowd. I was under the assumption all species travelled to Wistram to study, but I suppose those departing from Terandria *would* be mostly Human, don’t you?”

“Um. Yes. I suppose so.”

“Are you attempting to study magic at Wistram, or are you in another field? Alchemy, perhaps?”

“Uh, no. I want to advance further in the [Mage] class.”

Wistram didn’t just train [Mages], although that was the bulk of their graduates. A fair number of students would end up specializing in related fields like [Alchemist] or even [Blacksmith]—so long as magic was involved, any study was acceptable. But Ceria just wanted to become stronger. To have magic, to have power so she could—

“I’ve learnt several spells, but I’m only a Level 14 [Mage] at the moment. I’m told that’s quite high given that most students don’t know anything about magic, but I hope to improve myself beyond measure during my stay here. My focus is on basic elemental magic and some minor reinforcement-type magic at the moment, but I want to study every field I can. What about you?”

“Me? I’m just—I know a lot of attack spells, that’s all. I mainly focus on earth and fire spells. They’re my specialty.”

“Really? So you’re an adventurer? You use your magic for combat?”

Pisces seemed impressed. Ceria rolled her shoulder and nodded.

“I’m a Bronze-rank adventurer. I thought that I might be able to earn some money if I can learn more powerful spells at Wistram.”

If she wasn’t accepted as a student, she could at least try to learn one or two Tier 3 spells. Then at least she wouldn’t have wasted her money in vain. Pisces nodded energetically as the boat began to rock up and down. He didn’t seem to even notice the rocking that was making Ceria’s stomach churn slightly and had already made one of the Humans vomit.

The two kept talking as the Captain appeared below to announce that the trip would take two days if the weather held. Apparently, they’d hit a fast current and the weather was good. He told the Humans and Ceria that they’d get three square meals a day and that if they went above they were expected to stay out of the way of the sailors. Then he left them.

Ceria had no desire to go upstairs, but she noticed several people eager to stare at the ocean. A young man—a noble’s son with expensive clothing and even a wand she doubted he could use—was leading several other teenagers up the stairs already.

“So why did you decide to attend Wistram? I heard all half-Elves are far more talented than Humans at magic.”

The half-Elf shrugged uncomfortably.

“That’s only half true. Half-Elves are gifted at magic—we’ve got more in our bodies—but we don’t learn spells any faster.”

Of course, it was to their advantage to suggest that half-Elves were more powerful than they actually were. Ceria knew she was still an amateur as a mage, though. She was just barely strong enough to kill a few weak monsters with her spells. Something like Silver-rank was way beyond her still.

“So you want to improve your magic? I can respect that. Myself, I just find magic so exciting, don’t you?”

Ceria smiled briefly.

“I suppose it is. But I want to defend myself. With my spells, I can’t do anything but run if I meet a dangerous monster.”

“I’ve never fought a monster before.”

Pisces said it as he sat against one of the ship’s walls with Ceria. She glanced at his rapier. It was nearly hidden under his bedding and Pisces hadn’t referred to it. Nor had he really told her where he was from. They

were munching on the hard biscuits and salted cod that was their dinner. To Ceria's surprise, the meal had even included cheese and butter for their bread. It was no feast, but this was better than the rough fare she'd expected.

"How many monsters have you slain? A hundred? Or do Bronze-rank adventurers mainly just act as backup for stronger adventurers?"

Ceria coughed lightly to hide her embarrassment.

"I've uh, slain a few monsters myself. But we mainly work in teams."

She'd fought a few Goblins and cleared out any number of rats, but she could count the *real* monsters she'd fought on one hand.

Of course, that still put her far above the other new students in terms of ability.

"Astounding. Now, I know we can't practice any magic while aboard the ship, but do you mind if I ask you a few questions about the efficacy of spells in combat? I know only a few such as [Frozen Wind], but I was wondering—"

Pisces broke off and Ceria looked up as they noticed some other people coming their way.

"Well, I heard Wistram accepted everyone, but I thought they drew the line at freaks and trash."

A young man followed by a gaggle of other teens approached in the manner Ceria had come to recognize as the prelude to harassment. He stared down his nose at Ceria and Pisces.

"I am Charles de Tievalier, scion of my house. You would do well to address me with respect."

He was wearing the rich clothes to match, and he even had a shortsword buckled to his belt. It looked like it was purely ornamental, but Charles rested one hand on it as if he would like nothing better than to unsheathe it should the need arise.

Ceria raised one eyebrow. She wasn't intimidated by Charles, although she disliked him on sight. Moreover, unless he had quite a lot of levels in some combat class—which she doubted—she could put a [Stone Dart] through his eye before his blade even cleared the sheathe.

That made it slightly easier to listen to him speak.

"You—the one who was foolish enough to consort with the half-Elf. You would do well to stay away from such creatures."

Pisces blinked up at Charles and frowned.

“I will measure her worth independent of any outside opinion, thank you. Moreover, I don’t understand why you feel the need to come here and insult Miss Springwalker to her face.”

His diction was actually more polished than Charles’. Ceria saw it took the young lord back, and saw him reconsider his next words.

“Are you of the lesser nobility? Or a self-taught common citizen? Either way, only a fool would not know how insidious and untrustworthy the lesser species are.”

Lesser species. Ceria gritted her teeth. Charles was talking about her as if she wasn’t here. Pisces glanced at Ceria and his lips thinned.

“I believe you should go. If your aim was to have me remove myself, you have failed. Kindly do not disturb us again.”

“Ingrate!”

One of the young men standing behind Charles called out. He stepped forwards, a hand on his sword as well. What was with all these students and carrying weapons? Didn’t they know they were here to become mages?

The other young man glared down at Ceria and Pisces. He pulled his sword slightly out of its sheathe so they could see the costly steel blade.

“You dare insult one of the high nobility? I should have your head for that.”

Charles smirked and Ceria cursed inwardly. She didn’t know the countless aristocratic houses on the continent, but that explained why Charles already had a crowd around him. His family was undoubtedly as rich as they were powerful; his companions must have already been trying to suck up to him.

She expected Pisces to back down or deflect the anger, but instead he stood up. He had the rapier in his hands.

“I do not believe we have done anything that warrants a threat. This is a place for mages, not barbarians with metal sticks.”

The young man flushed. He unsheathed his blade—clumsily, Ceria noticed. He held the sword towards Pisces in an uncertain grip.

But even that was enough to silence the rest of the other students below decks. A bared weapon was dangerous, and the sword the young man held could kill no matter how inexpertly used. Ceria clenched her fist. She felt the magic flow into her hand. She didn’t want to use a spell and risk being thrown off the boat, but if it was that or Pisces getting hurt...

It didn't come to that. Pisces stepped back and unsheathed his rapier—quite a lot faster than the other young man had and with more of a flourish as well. Charles and his cronies stepped back as they saw the rapier, and uncertainty flicked in the sword-wielding youth's eyes.

"I would reconsider any attempts on our persons. Note the blade, please. I have levels in [Fencer] and I will not hesitate to defend myself."

The people around Charles backed up. He had his hand on his sword, but he was clearly unprepared for actual violence. He looked at the other young man with a sword and licked his lips before facing Pisces.

"You fool. Timor du Havrington is an experienced warrior who would cut you to bits. He has many levels in the [Warrior] class."

Timor nodded, but his eyes were on Pisces' rapier. He didn't hold himself like a warrior.

"Lower your blade, peon."

"Not until you do."

"I'm a [Warrior] and a [Lord]!"

His voice trembled. Pisces sighed. He reached into his pocket.

"If you will not reconsider your actions—then listen."

He pulled something out of his clothing. A silvery bell. It rang, a clear, high-pitched note. Once, twice.

Timor's face went pale. He leapt back from Pisces as if the other young man had struck at him. He stumbled into Charles and the two nearly fell to the ground.

"Stay back! We're both armed! Charles and I can take you on, regardless of your rank!"

Pisces held the rapier out calmly, facing sideways towards the two as Charles unsheathed his sword and faced him uncertainly. This had gone far further than Ceria had intended. She wasn't sure what the bell meant, but she couldn't let this continue. Ceria stood up.

"Back off. We're all on a ship going to Wistram. If you start a fight you'll get thrown off if the Captain doesn't kill you himself. And if he doesn't—I will."

She raised her fingers and concentrated. Flames erupted from her skin and danced around her hand. Charles and his followers backed away as the other students murmured and pointed.

"We have magic too!"

A few of the other people raised their hands and produced sparks or flames from their fingertips. None were nearly as vibrant as Ceria. She held her fiery hand out towards Charles until she heard pounding feet.

“What are you doing on my ship!?”

The flames around Ceria’s hand went out as she saw the [Captain] storming down the stairs, roaring at the students with two brawny sailors at his back. In moments everyone was separated and he was shouting at both Ceria, Pisces, and Charles and Timor, ignoring the latter two’s complaints.

“I should toss you all overboard myself! You two are lucky we’re far from port, or I would put you ashore and damn the list! You, boy, put that away before I throw that blade in the sea!”

The Captain shouted at Ceria and Pisces as he sheathed his sword.

“We were defending ourselves.”

Pisces protested, but the Captain was too incensed to listen. He glared at Ceria.

“I won’t have any magic on my ship! Cast another spell and I will toss you overboard myself! And you two, start trouble or draw a blade and I will cut you down, lords or not!”

He ignored the outraged noises the two boys made and stormed back up the stairs. Charles and Timor hesitated, but they stiffly walked away from Pisces and Ceria with only a parting glare.

Ceria sat back down with a sigh, heart pounding.

“That could have ended far worse.”

“Or far better. He threatened to throw away my blade!”

Pisces grumbled as he sat back down with Ceria. He was still glaring over at Charles and Timor, who’d joined the majority of the other students and were laughing loudly and *not* looking at Pisces and Ceria.

“Well, you were threatening two of his passengers.”

“Only because they drew steel on us!”

Pisces was indignant. Ceria sighed.

“If you hadn’t stood up to them, they would have left us alone soon enough. Trust me, I’m used to it.”

The young man looked sideways at Ceria.

“I didn’t feel it was right, that’s all. We’re all aspiring to become mages, proper mages, that is. If we can’t treat each other with basic civility, we’re no better than ignorant fools for all our power.”

Ceria smiled at him. It surprised her more than it surprised Pisces. Here she was, getting along with a Human of all people. He grinned back at her.

“Well, I enjoyed the looks on their faces when you stood up to them. Thank you.”

Pisces blushed and waved his hand.

“It was nothing.”

Ceria smiled again. She pointed to Pisces’ pocket.

“What does the bell mean? Those two backed off fast when they saw it.”

His cheeks were still flushed, but Pisces shook his head as he hid the rapier back under his bedding.

“It’s a token used by duelists. It means I’ve reached a level of skill recognized among anyone who practices the same craft.”

“Oh.”

It was obvious that he wanted to keep that a secret, so Ceria let it drop. Pisces muttered to himself as he rearranged his bedding.

“I dislike arrogant nobles and the like intensely. I thought I would be rid of them, but I suppose even in Wistram wealth speaks.”

“We’ll see if it holds true in the academy.”

“I’m told that there’s barely anything on the isle other than Wistram Academy and a pier. I wonder if they import all their goods? How do they feed themselves?”

“They probably grow what they need with magic. Somehow.”

“Still. How many new students will be like us, do you think?”

“Don’t know.”

“And how many will pass the exam?”

Ceria was silent. The exam. It loomed in her thoughts, a vague, terrifying specter.

It was true that anyone with a bit of talent and enough coin could travel to Wistram. But staying there was far harder.

Twenty gold pieces was the price, but that only bought each student a month’s time to study in Wistram. They would be taught basic magic and be given the run of the isle, but after that month they would have to prove their worth...or be sent home.

It was extraordinarily expensive to live in Wistram if you weren’t a mage offered a scholarship by the academy. Students would have to pay

hundreds of gold coins to study there, which was why most who went to Wistram hoped they could pass the exam and stay for free.

Wistram Academy was always looking for talented mages, so the exam was designed to allow students to showcase their talents. Anyone with a high level or better yet, some kind of unique spell or Skill would be allowed to study. It was what both Ceria and Pisces hoped to do; pass the exam and become full students.

But what the exam might actually be, and what they would learn in the time before then, neither Pisces nor Ceria had any idea. They had no idea what Wistram even looked like; it was in the middle of the ocean, and visitors to that isle were understandably rare.

Eventually, the light coming out of the portholes almost completely faded, and Ceria closed the one closest to her and Pisces so they could sleep. They still had another day and a bit to go, and she wanted to conserve her strength.

She slept soundly, until the storm began and rain began to pound the deck overhead.

It was a sea storm, the kind of horrific maelstrom that only emerged in the middle of the ocean. Huge waves battered the *Errant Traveller* as she sailed on through the dark clouds and pouring rain. Wind threatened to blow the sailors scrambling to lower sails and obey the Captain's orders as the man himself fought with the waves at the head of his boat.

Below decks, the students huddled in fear, listening to the *crash* of the waves and talking in quiet voices. Ceria sat with Pisces, watching through the window as the ship would go *up* and then come *down* with stomach wrenching force.

"Are you sure this boat can survive this storm?"

Pisces shouted in Ceria's ear. He was clutching his belongings as he stared out at the water.

"I don't know!"

Ceria shouted back. She tapped the window.

"This is glass. The ship must be newer, so it should hold!"

"It had better! I can't swim!"

"What?"

The idea that anyone couldn't swim baffled Ceria, until she remembered that many Humans from Terandria lived inland and never saw a large body of water. Not that it mattered. Ceria had had ample time to learn how to swim over the fifty years of her life, but she was certain she wouldn't last ten minutes in the frothing waves.

"We'll be okay!"

And then, as if to mock her, Ceria heard the hatch leading above slam open. A sailor pounded down the steps as wind and water blew in. He shouted.

"Sea Serpent to the starboard! *Stay below!*"

The people in the hold began to scream. Ceria's gut clenched in fear, but then the sailor was running towards her. He ignored the rocking motion of the ship as he seized her.

"You! Half-Elf! Do you have any spells that can fight off the serpent?"

Ceria stared at him, mouth open.

"Not a Sea Serpent!"

The vast monsters of the ocean were far more terrifying than those on land, at least in terms of size. A Sea Serpent was twice the length of a warship—and that was only on average. Bigger examples of their kind could take down an entire fleet. Ceria's [Stone Dart] spell would be as effective against it as spit.

"Fine. Stay here and pray it loses interest! The Captain's used a scroll to send for Wistram for help—maybe those damn mages will be able to do something from there!"

The sailor ran back up the stairs. Pisces turned a white face towards Ceria. She was already staring back out at the churning sea.

"There. There it is!"

In the distance, Ceria saw a rippling form scything through the water. The Sea Serpent shot out of the water head-first, a massive jaw and burning eyes the only impression Ceria received before it plunged into the water. Its serpentine coils followed it, and Ceria's heart froze in her chest when she realized the creature was four times as long as the *Errant Traveller*.

"Does it see us?"

Pisces gripped Ceria's shoulder. Even in the middle of her fear and panic, the touch filled Ceria with revulsion. She stared at his hand and had to fight to resist stabbing him. He was a Human male—no, he was Pisces and he was frightened. She pried his fingers loose and shook her head.

“Not yet! But it looks like it’s hunting!”

It was true. The Sea Serpent was questing about, diving through the waves as if it barely noticed them. It seemed to be searching for something. It dove, and then Ceria gasped as it came up with a struggling fish in its jaws. It must have been a massive fish, too, because it was clearly visible at this distance. It was only slightly bigger than the Sea Serpent’s mouth, but that already put it at least twenty feet across.

The serpent shook its mouthful and then disappeared again. Ceria prayed it had gone, but then its head shot up and it stared right at their ship.

Someone screamed. The Sea Serpent dove towards them, and then Ceria saw a huge mouth with teeth as it reared above their vessel.

She heard shouting overhead, and saw what looked like arrows shattering on the serpent’s scales. Two harpoons flew through the pouring rain, but they only lodged superficially in the creature’s scales without even drawing blood.

People were screaming and crying all around Ceria and Pisces. She just stared out the port hole. Pisces was mumbling to himself, clutching at his rapier.

“...not fair. I just wanted a chance. Is this how it has to end? Can’t even find a body to use...nothing big enough...”

“What’s that?”

Ceria muttered the words to herself. The serpent was *roaring* overhead, a vast alien shriek that sounded like death. Pisces looked up.

“What?”

“There’s something out there. In the storm. It—”

Lightning flashed. The world went white a millisecond before Ceria and Pisces felt the thunder that made the ship list sideways and travelled through their bones.

Boom. It was more of a feeling than sound. Ceria tumbled backwards and Pisces cushioned her fall. She scrambled upwards, ignoring the screaming, and saw the Sea Serpent twisting in agony.

“The lightning hit it!”

Indeed, part of the beast’s scales near its neck were blackened and torn away, exposing red flesh and blood that stained the waters. The serpent twisted and opened its jaws towards the ship, but then lightning struck again.

This time the *roar* of the bolt striking the serpent coincided with the light, so Ceria was blinded by the sight of a bolt of energy hitting the Sea Serpent as she was hurled to the deck. Pisces helped her up as he stared outside.

“It looks hurt! The lightning hurt it!”

Ceria rose to her feet slowly. She crouched, trying not to tumble over as she shouted back.

“That’s not lightning. That’s a *spell!*”

“*What?*”

“There!”

The half-Elf pointed, and Pisces gasped. In the sky, far overhead, the two mages could see a small figure hovering in the storm. The only reason they could pick her out was that the air was flashing around her, and electricity was crackling off her body.

“A mage? From Wistram?”

It had to be. Ceria stared at Pisces and saw his face was alight with the same hope in her chest. But then her heart sank.

“They only sent *one person?*”

Indeed, it seemed that way. The small figure was alone and she—yes, it was a woman—floated high in the air, facing the ship. But she was woefully small compared to her opponent, and now the Sea Serpent had seen her too. It roared and lunged out of the sea, snapping towards her.

The woman flew backwards, and Ceria felt the serpent hit the ocean, missing by only a few feet. The resulting wave turned the sea and sky into a confusing mess as more water rained around the ship, but then she looked up and saw the female mage dodging through the air again as the serpent chased after her.

“Look at it go! It can’t catch her!”

Pisces stared out another port hole as the woman flew through the air, the serpent launching itself at her time and time again. It couldn’t easily strike her while she was flying, and every time it shot out of the water she would spin out of the way. It was a wild, insane dance with death, but the mage flew around the serpent as if she was having *fun*.

The serpent snapped upwards and the woman dodged just in time. She flew right by the side of the ship Ceria was on and the half-Elf caught a glimpse of her face just for a second. She stepped backwards.

“What is it?”

Pisces stared at Ceria. She stared as the mage finally stopped, hovering just in front of the ship and facing the serpent. She had raised her hand and the serpent was charging towards her, unstoppable. It would hit the ship, but now electricity was crackling around the woman again.

“She’s...laughing.”

Ceria only saw her back now, but she knew what she’d seen. The woman raised her hand calmly as the serpent approached, as if she had all the time in the world. Ceria heard something shouted above the storm, and then the mage cast a spell.

Lightning flashed from her palm, a coruscating bolt of pure electricity. Ceria saw the afterimages as it struck the sea serpent, once, twice, three times, and then with so many bolts that the entire world went white.

Ceria covered her eyes as the explosion rocked the entire boat. She fell backwards and Pisces caught her. When she’d scrambled to her feet and peered back out the window, the woman was gone. The sea serpent’s body floated belly-up in the water, smoke rising as the rain pelted the massive corpse.

“Dead gods!”

The serpent was dead. Very dead. Its head was almost completely blackened, and only a stump remained where the gaping maw had been. Ceria and Pisces heard cheering from above, and then the ship was moving again.

“She killed it! Just like that! She was just *toying* with the serpent until now!”

Pisces shouted the words as the storm continued to rage around the boat. Ceria looked at Pisces. His eyes were shining with excitement. She knew she had a gigantic smile on her face, but she couldn’t wipe it away.

Almost all of the other candidates were screaming or still huddled in shocked silence. But the half-Elf and young man sat together, staring out the windows at the massive beast. It had seemed so incredible, so impossible to defeat. Even a ship full of trained sailors had been helpless before it, but a single mage had killed it in a matter of minutes.

Magic.

The boat *lurched* again and Ceria heard splattering as one of the students lost their lunch again. She saw something in the distance to the ship’s left—a dark silhouette jutting out from the sea. And then the ship was turning towards it, moving forwards.

That was when the storm cleared. All at once, the ship ceased rocking as it entered eerily calm waters. The raging wind and rain of the storm seemed to hit a wall, and then the boat was beyond, sailing underneath clear skies and above blue-green waters that sparkled in the light.

Ceria's mouth fell open. The *Errant Traveller* sailed into the heart of the storm, a magical bubble in which the weather ceased. The waters were suddenly smooth, and then the ship turned again and Ceria saw it clearly for the first time.

Wistram. The Isle of Mages.

The tall castle stood on top of a cliff—no, rather, it was built into the island itself. Tall rocky cliffs gave way to grey stone and Ceria saw that the castle was more like a citadel, not one building but a few interconnected ones, joined together by a thick wall and bridges that rose into the sky.

The spires and buildings rose out of the ground, impossibly high. Ceria had never seen any structure so tall—it seemed as though it were surely impossible, and from an architectural point of view, that had to be the case. Fat, round domes sat on top of narrow spires and entire wings of the castle stood out over the sea with seemingly no support.

It had to be magic; and indeed, Ceria could see shimmering lights in the air, and glowing runes visible to the naked eye hovering in the air around some windows, and more magic still. One tower looked like it was engulfed in *fire*, and another part of the castle was frozen, windows and part of the wall covered in creeping vines.

Ceria felt their ship slowing, and then spotted the dock. A huge, white dock made out of stone was their destination. Already two other ships were moored in the harbor, and one more was heading in, covered in rain from the storm. The mast on that ship was broken, but Ceria saw people on top of the deck, staring at Wistram.

Slowly, ever so slowly, the ship stopped and then sailors were securing ropes and the Captain was shouting at the students to gather their belongings. Almost numbly, the prospective students gathered their things and filed out of the ship.

Her breath caught in her chest the instant Ceria saw the castle in its entirety. A long stairway led up and up to two massive metal doors, and the castle towered higher still, glowing with magical light even in the daytime.

Pisces stood next to Ceria, just as entranced. They walked past the Captain, and Ceria only just remembered to thank him for taking them to

harbor safely.

“Don’t thank me. I’ve been paid for the trip, although this one was hardly worth the coin. That Sea Serpent would have broken my ship and all of us to bits had the mages not come to our rescue.”

The Captain shook his head as he stared at the second ship coming in to dock. Ceria hesitated.

“Do you know who that mage was? The one who slew the serpent?”

“Only one person it can be. That was Archmage Amerys. One of the King of Destruction’s Seven.”

Pisces gaped. The Captain shook his head.

“It was a stroke of luck, having one of the Archmages so close and inclined to help. Even so, it’s an omen for you who want to become mages. A good one or bad? Who knows. Be off with you, then, and best of luck.”

He turned away, and the two mages exchanged a look. They hurried after the students walking up towards the doors of Wistram. They were slowly opening, and people were coming down to greet the arrivals.

That was how they entered Wistram Academy. To the new students, it seemed as if nothing could top that first harrowing voyage through the storm, but they soon realized that they hadn’t the first inkling of the true mystery that lay within the ancient citadel.

The first thing Ceria noticed when she stepped inside Wistram’s massive halls was that the castle was, in fact, *massive*. In fact, the word massive was itself too small for Wistram. It would have gotten lost in the entrance hall, and that was already a place big enough to hold an entire village comfortably.

“It didn’t seem this big on the outside.”

“It must be magic! Some kind of spatial magic or—or we’ve been teleported!”

Pisces looked around the massive hall as Ceria eyed the lights hovering high, *high* overhead. Multiple floors overlooked the students as they filed into the center of the huge room, and Ceria could see people on the walkways connecting overhead.

“Tree rot. That’s stone up there! They’ve built bridges inside a room! This place must be enormous!”

“Yes indeed. Wistram is far larger than it appears from the outside. Mages have built high into the air and far underneath the isle. It takes a while before you stop getting lost, and even then you’d do well to stick to the main areas.”

Ceria and Pisces turned, and saw a tall man staring down at them. He had only a shirt on, probably because his lower half needed no clothes. He was a Centaur, and he grinned broadly at their surprise.

“It’s always the same. New students stare up and never even notice us. We could rob you all blind and you’d still be staring. Not that that would be a very nice greeting after the journey you’ve all had, would it?”

“You saw the Sea Serpent?”

Pisces exclaimed excitedly, and the Centaur laughed.

“The entire academy saw it. We were placing bets on whether Amerys would reach you in time. But you all made it, which I am glad for. My name is Calvaron, young mage. I am a full student of Wistram, and I’ll be showing you around.”

The Centaur mage offered both Ceria and Pisces a bone-crushing grip, and then raised his voice.

“Prospective students, this way! Your group will follow me to put your belongings away. Step quickly now, Humans! The next group will be following you soon!”

Heads turned. Ceria was pleased to see that Charles and his group of friends visibly hesitated when they saw their guide was a Centaur, but Calvaron ignored their looks. He began to trot down one of the large corridors, speaking loudly as he went.

“Congratulations on surviving your voyage! Not many people get to meet a Sea Serpent and live. But you’ll find life in Wistram just as exciting—if you stay, that is. We have you all for a month, and then the exam will see if you remain or have to go. Unless you can pay your way, that is. I hope to see at least some of you afterwards.”

Ceria had to hurry to keep behind the Centaur. He moved *quick*, and she saw Pisces was red-faced as he tried to juggle his belongings and keep up. He’d put his pack down when they’d entered, and now he was trying to put it on as he half-ran after them.

“Excuse me, Calvaron, can you slow down?”

“What? Oh, excuse me.”

Calvaron glanced over his shoulder and saw the Humans were struggling to keep up. He paused and Pisces looked gratefully at Ceria as he finally put his pack on his shoulders.

“I forget how slow you people are. But if you can’t keep up at Wistram, you might as well leave right now. Then again, other mages might have different opinions. Come on, you slowpokes! We’re nearly there!”

He bellowed at the stragglers, and then led them into a large room. Ceria froze the instant she entered and Pisces bumped into her. She stared up into the carved face of a seven foot tall Golem.

It had to be a Golem. Ceria only knew of one type of monster that had stone for skin, and no Gargoyle was carved to look like a beautiful woman dressed in clothing. Then the Golem moved, and Ceria gasped as she saw the robes shifting and moving with her, as if the solid rock were nothing but cloth.

“Greetings, young mage. I trust you are one of the new students?”

“I—I—”

“She is, Cognita.”

Calvaron stepped in smoothly for Ceria, as the other Humans entered the room and had similar reactions. Cognita, the massive Golem nodded graciously in turn until everyone had entered, and then spoke. Her voice was deeper than normal, and had a weight that made even Charles and Timor listen with rapt attention.

“I am Cognita. I am a Carved Golem, or rather, a Truestone Construct designed to oversee Wistram and its mages. I and my kindred maintain and preserve this building and will assist you for the duration of your stay. In a few moments you will be led to your rooms, but before that I must tell you of the rules of Wistram.”

She stared down at each person in turn, her emerald eyes serious.

“Firstly. You must never venture into the high parts of the castle or the lower reaches unaccompanied and even then, only with great cause. Dangers lurk within Wistram, ancient magics and spells and creatures called here and never destroyed. Too, the very enchantments keeping this citadel intact sometimes fray. Only a mage with true power is allowed into such places. Second. Some of the Golems here were made as I am, but most lack any form of intelligence and simply obey orders. Do not attack or obstruct them in any way or they may react unpredictably. Third. Anyone attempting to cast area-wide magics must first consult with I or an experienced mage.

Unpredictable results may occur if a spell affects a wide area of the academy at once. Is that understood?”

She stared down at the students and then nodded.

“That is all. Follow me, and I will lead you to your rooms and give you your keys.”

She walked through the doorway and Calvaron indicated that everyone should follow her. Ceria, Pisces, and Calvaron slipped to the back of the group as the other students filed out of the room.

“I’m surprised she didn’t have more rules. Like, don’t kill other students or not to steal.”

Ceria whispered to Pisces. Calvaron laughed when he heard that.

“Those are also against Wistram’s rules, but Cognita was created in a different time. She only cares if you study magic, and she only tells you those rules so you won’t get killed by accident. We’ll tell you all the rules later.”

“Calvaron. Will you lead these students to the dining hall now or later?”

Cognita had paused before a doorway. Calvaron nodded.

“Put your things away and take a moment to relax. In fifteen minutes I will bring you all to our dining hall to eat.”

The procession moved on, Cognita led each of the students to a door and handed them a key, or a stone, or sometimes just whispered in their ears. Ceria was bewildered, but then she and Pisces were left.

“This room shall be yours, Ceria Springwalker. Here is a key to the lock. It can be picked, so be wary.”

Cognita handed Ceria a key made of iron. Then she turned to Pisces.

“The door to your room is spelled. Speak your name into the lock and it will open for you alone. Be cautious that you do not lock a companion within.”

She turned, and left. Bemused, Ceria looked at Pisces as he wandered over to his door and spoke into it. The door swung open and Pisces blinked at the inside.

“Why are the locks different? And why are the *rooms* different?”

Ceria found her room was wide and spacious, filled with an old four-poster bed and a mirror and dresser in her room. Pisces had a much smaller room, but for some reason his came with a balcony that extended outside. He and Ceria looked at Calvaron who only shrugged.

“Lots of people worked on Wistram, and each person had their own style. Some doors have locks, while others use magic or a stone as a key. You got lucky, Pisces; a balcony spot is pretty nice to have. I imagine you could trade yours if you wanted.”

“I believe I will be content with my lodgings. Ah, did you say there was food available?”

Calvaron laughed as Ceria tossed her belongings on the bed and turned the key in the lock.

“Indeed there is. Let me gather the rest of your group and then we’ll eat. No one can learn magic on an empty stomach, right?”

Ceria and Pisces stared up in the great hall of Wistram, craning their necks to see the ceiling.

“Are those mage lights permanent, or are they just temporary enchantments?”

Calvaron looked up. He was sitting with both mages at one of the tables, crunching down on a meal that was mostly carrot, but had quite a bit of beef. He popped a chunk of carrot into his mouth as he spoke thoughtfully.

“I’ve never really asked. My guess is that it’s like a lot of the lights in the castle. They can be turned on and off, but the enchantment remains. Mind you, most mages will toss up a globe of light if it gets too dark and leave it there for a few hours.”

“Or a few days.”

Ceria turned. Sitting across from them was a dark-skinned woman wearing armor. What was unique about her was that her head and said armor weren’t attached. She was spooning pudding into her head on the table. Calvaron seemed perfectly at home with this, but neither Pisces nor Ceria had ever seen a Dullahan in the flesh before. Her name was Beatrice, and this was about the third thing she’d said throughout the course of the meal aside from ‘Hello’ and ‘Nice to meet you’.

Ceria stared around the vast room she was sitting in as she cut into her steak. The great hall was filled with long tables—and short ones. Like much of the castle, it seemed like any furniture was used, and so she’d found herself and Pisces sitting with Calvaron at a low table on some couches, rather than the long tables with chairs most of the students were dining at.

This was probably because the lower table allowed Calvaron to kneel on the ground while he ate. Ceria still couldn't quite focus on her food, though. The floating orbs of multicolored lights, the tables filled with all kinds of food—and especially the chatting, gossiping, laughing groups of every kind of species at every table was overwhelming her. She was surrounded by mages, and every few seconds Ceria would see someone cast a spell or illustrate their point with a cantrip.

“Stop staring, Springwalker. This food won't eat itself and if you want seconds, you'll have to eat fast.”

Ceria blinked at Calvaron, and then realized her steak was getting cold. She added some butter, watched it melt, and began scarfing the meat down.

Pisces was already eating as if he'd been starving. Neither he nor Ceria had the best table manners, but Calvaron and Beatrice didn't seem to notice.

“Where's all this food come from? Not magic, surely.”

“Hah! You think it just appears out of nowhere?”

Calvaron looked extremely amused. He pointed off to one side, towards the long buffet tables where they'd all collected their meals.

“Golems and [Chefs] do most of the cooking. Wistram hires the best, and what we don't eat they preserve for another day.”

“It must be handy, having a bunch of constructs to do most of the lifting and work around here. I don't know how you can deal with them so easily, though.”

Calvaron shrugged. He'd walked right past two of the huge, lumbering Stone Golems on the way here while Ceria and the others had walked as far away from them as possible.

“You get used to them pretty quick if you stay here. Beatrice used to hate all the enchanted armor around here. For two whole years she kept thinking they were other Dullahans and calling out to them.”

He laughed at Beatrice and she paused in feeding herself long enough to scowl at him. Pisces looked around.

“I appreciate that we are being fed immediately upon our arrival, but are you sure there's no welcoming speech? No introduction?”

“Do you want one?”

Calvaron waited until Pisces shook his head.

“Most mages don't care about new students. It's only the Expansionists and Revivalists that are interested in making sure there's a system, although every faction usually contributes in some way.”

“Expansionists? Revivalists?”

Pisces and Ceria exchanged a glance. Calvaron nodded.

“You’ll hear more about them soon enough. But Wistram isn’t one unified place. What you’ll learn quickly is that there are factions in here. Mages either band together or go it alone depending on their personalities.”

Ceria was surprised by that.

“So there isn’t a formal ceremony where we choose where we want to end up? I thought we’d be assigned to a group or...a faction or something.”

Calvaron laughed into his food and even Beatrice’s head smiled.

“Don’t be daft. Who’d be stupid enough to publicly announce which side you’re on? Not to mention that you can’t just put people into groups like that.”

He snorted and pointed at the new students.

“If you’re smart, you’ll choose wisely and tell no one at all if you do join a faction. Mind you, word will spread soon enough, but at least that way you’ll have a chance. And I hope you sell your loyalties wisely. It takes a strong mage to survive in Wistram alone, but better that than becoming a slave.”

He pointed down the hall, towards a small group of mages who were sitting alone. Their robes were clearly magical, and one was raising his voice and pointing at an illustration he’d conjured out of the air.

“See them? They’re Isolationists. They’d prefer that we stop accepting new mages into Wistram altogether, and have aspiring mages find their way here. It would weed out the casual applicants, true, but imagine how much business we’d lose!”

Beatrice scowled.

“Foolish. Wastes money.”

Calvaron rolled his eyes.

“Beatrice is a Revivalist. She’s part of the faction that thinks we should throw open our doors and usher in a new era of magic like in centuries past.”

“And you? What group do you belong to?”

The Centaur grinned.

“I’m undeclared, at least for now. I’ll probably join up with some faction or other, but I’m not important enough for them to start putting pressure on me yet. What about you, Pisces? Would you be an Isolationist or a Revivalist, given the chance?”

Pisces nodded to himself as he thought.

“Well, I am uninformed as of yet to all the nuances of the discussion, but my position would be—”

Ceria kicked Pisces under the table. He yelped and she glared at him. Calvaron laughed again.

“You’re learning quick, aren’t you?”

She was just planning to ask Calvaron about the different factions in Wistram when Ceria heard a sound. She turned her head and stared at one of the entrances to the great hall. A young man in disheveled robes burst into the great hall, shouting.

“*Ghouls!* They’re flooding the west hallways!”

For a second all was stunned silence, and then all of the new students started screaming. The young man fled into the hall, and then Ceria saw them.

Ghouls. They bounded out of the corridor, dead bodies leaping forwards with incredible strength and agility. Their eyes burned with unholy light.

She didn’t even pause to think. Ceria stood up and pointed her finger at the Ghouls. Without a wand she couldn’t cast strong magic, but she’d honed this spell until it was as deadly as an arrow.

“[Stone Dart]!”

A jagged piece of stone shot from her fingertips and caught one of the Ghouls in the chest. He stumbled, but came on. Ceria’s heart sank. Ghouls were far more dangerous than Zombies, and they were coming so *fast!* They’d be on top of the new students before they could flee.

“Stop screaming. [Ice Lance].”

Someone spoke up from behind Ceria. She turned her head just in time to see a massive block of ice shaped into a point shoot past her. The wind blew her hair and Ceria turned back to see the Ghoul she’d struck and three more had been smashed to bits by the spell.

“[Silent Sickle]!”

Another mage across the hall pointed without even getting up from his meal. One of the ghouls was sliced to bits by transparent scythes and another lost its legs.

“[Earth Cannon]!”

“[Invisible Arrow]!”

“[Slippery Floor].”

All around Ceria, mages pointed or waved their wands or used their staves to cast spells. The Ghouls practically disintegrated under the combined mass of spells until all that was left was a completely ruined floor as ice spells and fire spells created steam and sticky and slippery substances mixed on the ground or began to dissipate.

Calvaron laughed as he tugged Ceria back down into her seat.

“Nice spell, new student. But leave the fighting to the older mages, alright? We can handle ourselves.”

“Is that normal? The Ghouls?”

Pisces pointed to the remains of the Ghouls—a single hand and a few stains on the stone floor. Already a Golem was lurching over to the mess with a mop and bucket in hand.

Both the Centaur and Dullahan shrugged.

“It’s not usual that we get monsters that come as far as the dining hall, but accidents happen. I wonder how the undead got here? Teleportation spell gone wrong?”

“Dead corpses?”

Beatrice scratched at her head. It was more of a massage since she could scratch every spot at will. She pointed at the distraught mage who’d ran into the room.

“Probably an experiment with some bodies. Too much magic. Must’ve reanimated them.”

“True. I’ll ask later. Anyways, bear that in mind, you two. If you want to stay at Wistram, you’ve got to be prepared for anything. Sea Serpents are the least of your worries here. Do you think you can handle it?”

He looked both Ceria and Pisces in the eye. She hesitated, but then nodded with conviction.

“I’m staying.”

Pisces nodded. He swallowed a huge gulp of food and wiped at his mouth with a napkin.

“So am I!”

“That’s what they all say.”

Calvaron laughed with Beatrice, although she just chuckled. Then he grew serious.

“Unfortunately, I’ve got some bad news for you two. This year there are nearly twice as many prospective students as usual. I’m afraid that unless

you're over Level 20 or you've got some new spell or talent, you'll be hard-pressed to pass the exam."

He paused as both new students exchanged a dismayed look.

"Well, unless you have a patron to sponsor you."

"A patron?"

"A high-level mage."

Beatrice translated. Calvaron nodded as he crunched on another carrot.

"Someone who will vouch for your abilities. That would allow you to skip the exam altogether."

Ceria eyed Calvaron.

"I don't suppose you...?"

"Sorry, I don't have the influence to help anyone. We're all novice mages here. Only one of the teachers or one of the older mages can do that, and they don't usually interfere with the exam. Plus, a lot of the ones assigned to teaching duty this year aren't too happy."

"Like Illphres. She's angry."

"Who?"

"The mage who cast [Ice Lance]. That's her, over there."

Ceria looked over and saw an older woman dressed in robes sitting with the group Calvaron had identified as the Isolationists. She was scowling at another mage as he spoke. Calvaron lowered his voice.

"She's going to teach you some elemental magic. But ah, she's... temperamental. She's one of the best [Cryomancers] in the academy, though."

"Is [Cryomancer] the same as [Ice Mage]?"

"Different names. Sometimes different specializations, but usually the same."

"Oh."

Ceria kept staring at Illphres. She'd cast a Tier 4 spell – [Ice Lance] in mere seconds, without even using a wand! Ice magic wasn't Ceria's specialty, but she was still impressed by the spell.

But it seemed not everyone shared her opinion. Reacting to what one of the mages had said, Illphres said something angrily which earned her a scoff and a flick of the hand from the talkative mage. Ceria saw Illphres raise her hand and then the mage who'd been talking was blasted off his feet by a huge swathe of snow.

He went flying into another table. Ceria winced as she saw the mage smash into plates and cups and splatter the diners sitting there. One woman calmly wiped food off her face, and Ceria's heart skipped a beat as she recognized Amerys, the mage who had slain the Sea Serpent.

Amerys looked across the room at Illphres and raised a finger. Ceria ducked and the lightning bolt *exploded* against the icy wall Illphres had conjured, sending fragments of ice into the air like hail.

More screaming erupted as the Isolationists all surged to their feet. Amerys grinned and the mages around her began casting spells. Ceria watched as a full-blown fight erupted between the mages in the hall as more and more joined in. She could hear shouting as well, from other groups of mages who were just defending themselves or staying outside of the conflict altogether.

"Take cover!"

"Damn it! It's Amerys and Illphres again!"

"Careful! You nearly hit my plate!"

"Someone put up a shield spell before those students get killed!"

Calvaron chuckled as Beatrice threw up a magical barrier that caught an incoming bolt of magic. He glanced over at Ceria and Pisces as they stared at the magical war breaking out among the mages.

"Don't worry. People hardly ever get killed. They're just having a disagreement; I doubt they even realized you lot were coming in today. Just don't disturb them while they're working, don't wander off into far off parts of the isle, ask for help, don't choose a side right away, and never get in the way of the Golems."

He paused and scratched at his head as one of the mages shot a stream of purple bubbles out of a wand that immobilized an entire table of students.

"Anything else they should know, Beatrice?"

She shrugged.

"Don't die. And welcome to Wistram."

Wistram Days (Pt.2)

Where did the magic come from? It came from the air around her, the hard wooden desk she sat at, and herself. It flowed through her blood, ran through her hair—it was in her. Ceria reached into her inner self and found magic there. With each breath she took, with each pump of her heart, the magic lived through her.

She drew a portion of it out now, and gave it shape. She pushed, and made the magic condense into a small ball, drawing in itself. Becoming...

Water. The clear liquid flowed into existence, forming a shaft of brilliance in the sunlight. And then, as Ceria held it in place in the air, she froze it.

Water pooled and stiffened, the clear liquid clouding, becoming solid. Ceria watched as the pointed tip of the icicle gleamed, ready to be launched. It was a small missile she'd made—barely longer than her middle finger, in truth. But the [Ice Dart] spell had been designed for rapid-fire attacks en masse. With it, she could turn a Goblin into a pincushion or overwhelm another type of monster.

This dart was of better...construction...than most. That was to say, when Ceria usually used the spell she was concentrated more on speed than aesthetic or form. As a result, some of her darts would have jagged edges or be angled awkwardly, as if the icicles had bent while being frozen. That could cause them to veer off from their targets, or fail to do as much damage.

But this? This was an ideal form of the spell. Ceria stared at the frozen missile floating in front of her and smiled. It was the perfect example of her magical talents, and her superior half-Elven heritage. She'd barely felt the effort of making the spell. That would prove—

“And just *what* do you call this?”

A hand reached out and touched the floating shard of ice. Ceria blinked as a rather tall, dark-haired man in robes lifted the product of her spell up and regarded it with disdain. He sniffed at it, and then snapped at her.

“*Focus*, Springwalker. Your [Ice Shard] spell mixes the cold and water aspects together. You are freezing the water you create rather than forming the shape and solidifying it as separate stages.”

His hand didn't glow red, but for a second the air rippled with heat around his hand. In a moment, Ceria's [Ice Shard] was gone, evaporated in a puff of steam which instantly dissipated.

"Try again, and this time *concentrate*. Your spells need to be well-formed, not leaking pools of wasted mana."

"What? What's wrong with my spell?"

She couldn't help the words as they burst from her mouth. Ceria glared indignantly up at the [Mage] who'd dissipated her spell. He stared back, eyes cold and annoyed.

"Your composition was weaker, due to the air trapped within the icicle as you froze the water while making it. In addition, the spell itself was not straight—it deviated slightly near the tip. Finally, the point was unsharpened; merely a blunt tip."

"But—"

Ceria knew it was true. Even so, she felt the need to deny the criticism.

"It's *almost* fully correct! Those are just minor details!"

Another sniff.

"Details are what set apart true mages from amateurs. If you wish to lower your standards, Wistram is not the place for you. Try again, and this time concentrate properly."

Ceria heard laughter around the class and felt herself going red. Blood rushed to the tips of her pointed ears, but she said nothing. She ground her teeth as she focused again on the spell, trying to tune out the world around her.

The man who'd admonished her so casually—the senior [Mage] in charge of this class's magic lesson named Rievan Forstrom—walked on without a backward glance.

That had been humiliating. And unfair! Ceria tried to focus on her spell again, but this time her concentration was shot. The magic in her and around her was harder to control, and she was having trouble condensing it into a physical form.

There were still people chuckling in the large room Ceria was taking her second class of the day in. She heard one particularly obnoxious voice laughing louder than the rest.

Charles de Trevalier made no effort to conceal his glee at Ceria's upbraiding. Worse, Rievan didn't seem to mind. The mage walked over to another student and began talking in a loud voice, lecturing the unfortunate

girl about the quality of her spell, a bundle of sparks that was supposed to be the [Electric Jolt] spell.

After he'd gone, and the other students were talking again, comparing notes, complaining, or just making conversation, the young man sitting at the desk next to Ceria leaned over. Pisces lowered his voice so only she could hear him as he whispered.

"I thought the spell was appropriately formulated. I rather think the true crux of the issue is that he doesn't like you."

He nodded to Rievan, and Ceria saw their instructor was showing the Human girl how to do the spell properly. Neat, focused webs of lightning flashed from one of his palms into the other. He was certainly critical of the girl, but he wasn't being *nearly* as sharp with her as he had been with Ceria.

She made a face. Yes, their instructor for the new students taking the Magical Foundations class did seem to have it out for her. And she was under no illusions as to why.

He was Human. Ceria was a half-Elf. But more importantly, she thought that he might be a Human who'd originally grown up in Terandria, which would explain his dislike for her.

"As if he'd ever tried casting a spell while fighting off a Goblin tribe."

She grumbled as she tried to form the spell again. Maybe she should give up and try [Stone Dart] or [Flame Jet] instead? But no, he'd probably just reprimand her for giving up on the spell. Pisces looked sympathetic as Ceria tried to spin the water out from her fingertips and hold it in position before she froze it again.

They were in class. It was slightly odd for Ceria to be sitting in this neat room at a small desk—she'd never gone through anything like this growing up—but Wistram taught countless students each year, and they'd developed a process to teach their students as a whole.

One of these ways was giving the prospective students a variety of mandatory courses to take during their first month. Each day, the students had countless lessons and magical theorems and basic spells hammered into them by various mid-level [Mages]. And in one of those classes, this one, the basics of magic were being re-taught to Ceria, much to her displeasure.

Basic magic. Pure magic. People had many names for the subject, but this class had been introduced as elementary magic by their instructor. Ceria hated it.

The study of basic telekinesis, magical composition and fundamental aspects of magical theory like spellcraft were lumped into one category by most mages. It was a branch of magic few practitioners focused on, outside of learning how to levitate small objects and refine their mana flow and so on. Nonetheless, it was vitally important for any mage who wanted to cast spells, and so most mages grew passable at forming their spells properly. A bent [Ice Shard] spell would be far less effective, just like how a poorly-made warding spell might not block all the arrows properly.

It was important, yes, but tiresome. Mages specializing in this rare field liked to refer to it as ‘pure’ magic. Others, Ceria included, thought of it as boring magic. And she was all the more angry because her spells were good, damn it!

She didn’t need to work on her [Ice Shard] spell. What Ceria wanted was to start learning more advanced spells, but she was stuck. Probationary Wistram students took all the classes they could, and Ceria knew that the efficacy of her spells would be tested during the examination process at the end of the month. So she gritted her teeth and reapplied herself to forming the best [Ice Shard] spell she could.

At the desk next to her, Pisces focused on his own spell. He didn’t know any Tier 2 combat spells, so he was casting [Electric Jolt] as well. Rievan had taught the entire class the spell, but he’d insisted that anyone who knew a higher-Tier spell should practice that instead. The more complex a spell was, the more a mage benefited from working with it.

The young man let a spark of electricity jump between his fingers, almost in a straight line. He seemed focused and at ease at the same time—eager to learn, and not at all bothered. He kept talking as Ceria labored over her spell.

“I really hadn’t considered the implications of altering a spell in its base state. Had you, Ceria? Certainly it makes no sense to significantly alter basic constructions and increase the complexity, but had you considered what would happen if you turned your [Ice Shard] spell into, say, an orb? Wouldn’t that completely change the nature of the spell?”

Ceria grunted irritably as she tried to make the point of her shard sharper.

“The mana cost’s the same, and so is the amount of water you can work with. What’s the point? A ball of ice isn’t useful, and round shapes are harder.”

Pisces grinned.

“Well, I was just thinking, if we can alter basic spells like that, what’s the point in learning spells at all? We could just learn basic fundamental magics and extrapolate from there. It might take a long time, but if we could *teach ourselves* magic—”

“I see you have time to talk rather than practice.”

The loud voice made Pisces and Ceria both jump. She cursed as her attention wavered and the water she was holding in place lost its form. The young man sat up quickly as Rievan loomed over his desk, looking down his sharp nose at him.

“You are new, are you not? Your name is...Pisces.”

“Yes sir.”

Pisces looked ahead respectfully while Rievan scowled at him. He didn’t appear intimidated, just alert and wary. And confident. Ceria didn’t see a bit of doubt in his posture.

“You have not yet been admitted as a full student to Wistram. I suggest you dedicate yourself to studying, while you have time. But since you do not feel the need—show the class how far you have progressed with your [Electric Jolt] spell.”

The other practicing students looked over as Pisces raised his hands. Rievan was clearly expecting Pisces to make a mistake and pounce on it, but to his surprise—and Ceria’s—a steady stream of purple-blue lightning crackled from one of Pisces’s hands into the other, looking for all the world like a bright river of electricity.

Drops of water splattered on Ceria’s desk and evaporated as she lost control of her own spell. She was gaping. Just a bit. Pisces’ control of the spell was immaculate. Both she and Rievan knew it. After a moment, the mage nodded. He looked at Pisces with a hint of respect and addressed the other students as a whole.

“Acceptable. Observe, class. Young Pisces has managed to divert the whole of the spell into striking his other palm, without letting the individual threads of magic separate as the electricity desires. Emulate his example. Learn from it. We will focus on the same tomorrow, by refining your basic levitation spells. Class dismissed.”

He whirled and walked towards the door. Pisces paused, letting himself smile a tiny bit. Then he turned to Ceria.

“Shall we go?”

“How did you do that?”

“It’s just a matter of adjusting the spell.”

“I know *that*—”

Ceria snapped as she hurried after Pisces. She had to walk fast to keep up with him—Pisces was taller than she was, and he had an effortless stride despite the small bag he carried. She was carrying a similar one, and Ceria didn’t like the weight it put on one shoulder. The strap was digging into her flesh. Why didn’t Humans use backpacks? They were more practical, if not as easily accessible.

They were walking through the corridors of Wistram, leaving the class they’d just been in. Ceria and Pisces stopped in a large corridor and found a number of other students—all young, prospective students like them—milling around there.

They were in one of the sections of Wistram devoted to teaching. As such, a branching corridor led to several hallways with classrooms, and it was the intersection here where students could find a class, or walk to another intersection to go elsewhere in Wistram.

“Why are you so amazed? It’s not as if the spell was Tier 3, or even Tier 2. Your [Ice Shard] spell was far harder to maintain.”

“In terms of mana, maybe. But your mastery of the spell was nearly perfect. Even the teacher left you alone! Are you *sure* you didn’t know the spell beforehand?”

“Very sure. I just don’t find Tier 1 spells that challenging, at least in making them work in the most optimal way. It’s like having a map with your destination circled; it’s obvious what needs to be done.”

“Well.”

Ceria blew out her cheeks, partly exasperated, but mostly impressed. Pisces certainly was gifted. She looked around the other corridors and frowned.

“Where to next?”

Pisces frowned. He stared at one of the windows. The sun was nearly directly overhead. Wistram had other ways of telling time of course, but this was the easiest to use.

“Um...illusion class, I think. After that’s destruction magic.”

“So we’re free?”

“Unless you’ve figured out where the illusion class is being held yet?”

“Nope. You?”

Pisces shook his head. Ceria looked around and saw the other students were milling about, equally confused as to where to go. She gritted her teeth, annoyed.

“I can’t believe there aren’t any signs.”

“Or a map. That would be quite helpful.”

There was a trick to Wistram. Actually, more than one trick; it was like walking into a dungeon full of traps, really, but there was a trick to being a student that Ceria had quickly realized. And it was that being a student meant you had to learn *everything*. Not just magic. Even basic things like directions, where the bathrooms were located—all of that vital information you had to find out for yourself, because no one would teach you.

Class, for instance. Ceria had heard of royal academies some nations had founded to train [Strategists], or [Scholars] and even [Mages] of their own, but where those places were neat, highly-regulated affairs, Wistram clearly believed in finding things out for yourself.

Case in point. The first day Ceria and Pisces had been in Wistram—the first full day, not counting their exciting voyage and rescue—they’d been given a tour of Wistram, as well as supplies to be used during their time here. Ink pots, quills—even a low-level spellbook of their own! Calvaron had been one of the students who’d shown Ceria where to go and not to go, and what places were off-limits to new students like her.

Only, it appeared that while older students like Calvaron had been only too willing to show the new students around the first day, they hadn’t pointed out specific classrooms. Thus, when class had actually started, Ceria had had to run around with Pisces, walking into classes in session before they found the one they were assigned to.

This was embarrassing, but not the worst part. Some classes were easy enough to figure out, and the teachers had even posted directions on the large message board next to the dining hall. But no matter how hard Ceria and the other students had searched, they still hadn’t found some of the other classes they were slated to attend. The illusion classroom was *supposed* to be somewhere on the ground floor, but no one had found it yet.

Ceria was certain that was some kind of twisted joke. She scowled as she wondered what she might be learning if she was in the right class—she

didn't know any illusion spells, and she would dearly love to learn one or two. But she yawned once, which prompted Pisces to yawn as well.

"I don't wish to seem lax, but I very much doubt three more hours of unsuccessful searching would do either of us any good, do you?"

"Probably not."

"Then I shall return to my room for a quick rest. Would you like to...?"

Ceria thought about it as Pisces eyed her hopefully. Her instinct was to say 'no', but it wasn't as if Pisces was inviting her into his room. And besides—

"Fine. Let's go."

She and Pisces began walking out of the intersection. Their departure seemed to make up the other new student's minds, and they began to leave too. Soon, the wide corridors were packed with busy people, some tripping over their robes.

Robes. Ceria snorted as she walked along in her normal, *practical* leggings and tunic. Over half of the new students were wearing long robes, usually dark blue or black. They'd bought it along with a low-quality wand, as if it were prerequisite for being a [Mage]. All it really did, in Ceria's opinion, was make you look like an idiot. The older students, Calvaron and Beatrice included, didn't wear robes. Then again, Calvaron was a Centaur and Beatrice was a Dullahan, so perhaps that was an unfair comparison.

This time Ceria took the lead, which meant that she could set the pace. Pisces walked next to her, easily keeping up as they turned left and right and went up a flight of stairs. Both had to concentrate on where they were going—there wasn't much traffic in the hallways except at the busiest of intersections, but Wistram was a labyrinth. It was all too easy to get lost and turn the wrong way and find yourself quite a ways away from where you wanted to be.

"I thought that was a rather informative class, don't you?"

"Maybe."

Ceria grunted as she walked along. She made a face. She was still sour over being reprimanded.

"I certainly benefited from someone showing me how to cast the [Electric Jolt] spell, and the way our teacher optimized the spell was quite interesting."

"That I'll grant you. Still, learning to make a weak spell slightly more effective wasn't why I came here."

Ceria stopped at an intersection where two paths split off diagonally from each other. It was odd architecture, and Ceria couldn't remember which way led to their rooms. Pisces pointed.

"I think we go right here. Well, what did you expect?"

"I don't know. I guess I thought we'd be picking up higher-Tier spells, not working on the basics."

"I would like that. But we *are* new students, aren't we? If we don't improve on our fundamental abilities, we wouldn't be able to cast better spells anyways."

That was true. Ceria knew [Ice Shard], but she could barely create more than twenty darts before she had to sit down. That was a far cry from a good mage's capabilities, let alone a Gold-rank [Mage], for example.

"I guess you're right. Still..."

She scowled, not wanting to put her feelings into words. She walked briskly forwards, and Pisces stepped a bit more quickly to catch up.

She knew they had to make an odd pair. Ceria was a half-Elf, and Pisces was...well, a young man who looked more like a peasant than a student. There were odder pairings, Calvaron and Beatrice for example, and Ceria had seen Drakes and even a Selphid walking down the halls just this morning. But it was strange to be talking so familiarly with a Human, given where both came from.

Pisces cleared his throat.

"I noticed the lecturer was ah, slightly hostile towards you, Ceria. Maybe it's because of your..."

"My race, you mean?"

Ceria grimaced as she twitched her ears in annoyance. Pisces made a noncommittal sound.

"Straight ahead here, I believe. Do you think he's from Terandria?"

She shrugged.

"He could be. If he lived in the north or eastern parts of the continent... or not. It doesn't really matter—half-Elves don't have a good reputation anywhere."

"Really? I know that some nations in Terandria ah, don't have the best relations with your people, but everywhere?"

"You've heard the rumors about half-Elves, right? We're thieves, we can't be trusted, we hate Humans—"

“But those are rumors, surely. Just like how you can’t let a Selphid into a graveyard, and a Gnoll will bite your face off if you offend them.”

“Yeah. I mean—yes. Come on, it’s this way.”

Ceria turned away from Pisces. She wasn’t used to someone taking her side, and it was uncomfortable.

“Okay, maybe in other parts of the world we’re more welcomed, but half-Elves keep to ourselves no matter where we go. And if he *is* from Terandria, there’s bad blood. Lots of it. Centuries of conflict.”

“Indeed. I just didn’t think he was being that fair in his critique of you, that’s all.”

“Well—thanks.”

They walked on. Ceria began to recognize their part of the citadel as the view in the windows changed. She and Pisces occupied some sort of overlook right above the rocks of the isle, and as she stared out at the calm, peaceful bubble of water surrounding Wistram, she spotted their rooms.

“Here we are.”

“Here we are indeed.”

Pisces nodded to Ceria.

“I’ll ah, take a nap. Would you like to have lunch together later?”

“I—guess so. Okay. See you later.”

He nodded, smiled, and yawned. Ceria yawned too, and she found herself fumbling with the lock in her keyhole. She tossed her heavy bag onto a chair, wincing as she heard a sealed pot of ink *clink* against the wood, and rubbed at her shoulder. Then she yawned again.

It was strange. Ceria was *exhausted*, and the day wasn’t even truly begun. Five hours had passed since they’d woken up. Well, six, but the first hour had just been comprised of dressing, eating, and finding their way to class. The other five had involved studying.

Maybe if it was just studying in the sense of reading books and listening to someone talk Ceria would have been more awake. But in Wistram, studying also meant casting magic. She’d been taught several basic spells and forced to use her mana to prove to her teachers that she could perform basic incantations. That wasn’t hard, but she’d had to do it again and again.

Repeatedly casting spells, even low-Tier ones, was extremely draining. The result was that even at midmorning of their second day, both Ceria and Pisces felt physically exhausted, if not mentally. They wandered into their

rooms and fell asleep for a few solid hours before waking bleary-eyed and restless.

Of the two, Ceria was the most exhausted. She barely managed to rouse herself for a very late lunch after Pisces knocked on her door, and she stumbled into the grand dining hall with a scowl as she got her food.

Raucous laughter greeted both her and Pisces as they sat at one of the tables. Calvaron and Beatrice were seated at a large table next to the couches, and they waved the two new [Mages] over. Ceria hadn't seen them much yesterday, but she saw the two older students were studying at their table while they ate.

Spell books, expensive, magical, and sometimes literally glowing with the spells inscribed on them, were carelessly propped open by bowls and mugs. The Dullahan and Centaur looked like they'd been eating and sitting for a while, judging by the mess on their table. Calvaron swept some dishes aside as he called out to Ceria.

"Your hair looks like a tangled spiderweb, Springwalker! Did you get a bit of rest after all the magic practice this morning?"

She glared at him as she put down her food—thick slices of roasted mushrooms in a sauce and what she thought was pork—on the table.

"I'd laugh—but I forgot that I don't like jokes."

"Ooh, touchy. Are you in the same class as Ceria, Pisces? I'd sit far away from her if I were you, or she might bite your head off."

"I can leave. Or throw these mushrooms at you."

Calvaron ducked his head slightly as Ceria raised her fork with one of the dripping mushrooms.

"Don't, please. I hate mushrooms."

"I'm allergic to mushrooms."

The Centaur, Human, and half-Elf all looked at Beatrice. She was calmly eating some peas, chewing without much expression.

"Sorry. I can take them away if it's a bother."

"Just don't drop them on my armor."

Ceria nodded and settled down as she began to eat her meal. Calvaron wasn't done teasing though. The Centaur grinned at the two others.

"Did you just wake up? Exhausted, are we?"

"Quite."

Pisces nodded as he stuffed his face full of meat. He'd completely ignored the mushrooms as well.

“I had no idea—mnph, this is good—that the lessons could be this intense. Will they always be so hard?”

Beatrice looked mildly disgusted at Pisces’ display of eating. She moved her head off the table and onto her lap as Calvaron nodded and laughed again.

“Everyone always complains on the first day. Have you two never been taught by another [Mage] before?”

Ceria shook her head, ruefully.

“I learnt all my spells from books. I taught myself.”

Pisces hesitated before replying.

“There was a local [Hedge Mage] in my...village who agreed to teach me.”

Calvaron nodded as he reached for a drink of dark purple juice. Ceria smelled grape and wished she’d gotten some.

“The first lessons are always the hardest. Once they’re sure you’re not making novice mistakes in how you form your spells, the teachers will go easier on you.”

“I hope so. But do we have to take classes at all? I thought Wistram let mages study how they pleased.”

Scowling, Ceria bit into another mushroom, chewing hard. *Someone* hadn’t cooked these thoroughly enough. Beatrice and Calvaron shrugged in reply.

“Some people just study by themselves. But until you’re sure that’s the way you want to go, I’d pay attention in the lessons and try to impress the mages assigned to teach you.”

“For the exam.”

“Exactly!”

The Centaur grinned as Ceria’s stomach gave a small lurch and Pisces paused long enough to look worried.

“Will we learn any complex spells before then?”

“Some basic ones, yes, but complex? Not unless your teacher’s quite odd. You lot are only here for a month—all of your courses are the most basic ones.”

Beatrice nodded.

“Boring classes.”

“Golem creation, scroll scribing, trap spells and enchantments—all of that only gets taught when we’re in our second years at the earliest. Most

students don't get to those kind of lessons until year *six*. Talented ones get there sooner, but..."

"Wonderful."

Ceria muttered as she drank her own cup of water. Pisces looked dispirited as well, but then he turned to the older students hopefully.

"If you're going to be helpful, mind telling us where the illusion classes are being taught? No one's found the classroom so far."

"Oh? Illusion class?"

They laughed. Well, Calvaron laughed and Beatrice chuckled. Ceria frowned at them.

"What's the joke?"

The Centaur scratched at his head and smiled enigmatically at the two of them.

"I...*could* tell you how to find it, but I'm afraid I'd have to charge you two for that."

"What? You'd ask us for *money*?"

Ceria was outraged—she'd thought the Centaur and Dullahan were friends, or at least friendly!—but Calvaron was shaking his head, trying not to chuckle.

"No, you see—ah, Beatrice, what should I do? If I explain it, I'll lose the chance to charge them for that as well. Do you think we should just give away a secret like that?"

The half-Elf had no idea what they were talking about, but Beatrice paused for a second before nodding her head with her hands.

"It's not a big secret. You should tell them to be friendly. Or she'll throw mushrooms at us."

Calvaron glanced at Ceria. She was indeed considering heaving her dish at his head. Pisces just watched the other two thoughtfully. At last, Calvaron sighed, sounding put-upon.

"I suppose we can. Okay you two, you're about to learn a bit more about how Wistram works. For free, no less."

"What *are* you talking about?"

Beatrice sighed.

"They are a currency. Secrets."

Calvaron paused, mouth open and looked over at Beatrice with a frown. Ceria and Pisces just stared at the two of them.

"Thanks for ruining my moment, Beatrice."

“Welcome.”

The Dullahan shrugged impassively. Ceria stared at her and the resigned Centaur.

“What?”

“You heard her. Wistram runs on secrets, not coin around here. You would have figured it out sooner or later, but...”

“I still don’t get it.”

“It’s very simple. If you want something—a spell, a favor, or even another secret, you have to pay for it. Unfortunately, or fortunately for those of us without money, the most valuable thing around here is secrets.”

“Secrets.”

Ceria felt like she was speaking another language. Calvaron wiggled his eyebrows as he smiled at her.

“That’s right. Secrets about where treasure’s buried, unique classes, spells no one’s heard of—I say secrets, but it’s more general knowledge in most cases—”

“What are you talking about?”

“Secrets, Springwalker! Secrets!”

Pisces stopped Ceria from getting up and kicking the table over. He smiled at her.

“I believe Calvaron is saying Wistram uses a bartering system.”

“What?”

It took a while, but with Calvaron to explain and Pisces to clarify—and Beatrice to nod silently—Ceria finally got it.

Wistram used secrets like coins. Small secrets, big secrets—they were what [Mages] and students alike traded each other for favors, or even real objects.

“Like coin? You could trade a secret for a—a bag of gold coins?”

Calvaron nodded happily as he ate something yellow and strange he called a ‘banana’. It looked disgusting to Ceria.

“That’s right. Wistram doesn’t have much use for coin, although there are always merchants sailing in to harbor...but secrets and magic are the real coin around here.”

“But how does that work? Are there really that many secrets there? No—how could you keep that many secrets for so long? How could a system like that keep functioning?”

The Centaur shrugged.

“It works because it has to. We need some kind of currency, and money isn’t good enough. And secrets have a weight of their own. True, if you went around telling everyone then the secret’s worthless. But if there were a room only you and someone else knew about—or a part of the academy that you have to have a password to get into—”

“Which there are.”

“—Which there are, thank you Beatrice. The system might not work anywhere else, but Wistram has so many secrets and hidden surprises that even now people are finding new things out. Just the other day, someone found a wall that disappears if you say the right words.”

“Oh? And what was behind the wall?”

Pisces was curious, but Calvaron just waggled a finger at him.

“If I told you that, you’d have to give me a secret. A small one to know and a big one for the actual words, which I don’t in fact know. I’d have to trade some secrets for it, you see.”

“That is the *stupidest* way of—”

Ceria rubbed at her head. This had to be a joke. She closed her eyes and came up with a flaw after two seconds of thought.

“What if—and hear me out here—what if someone traded you for a secret, and then didn’t pay up? How would anyone prove you’d lost anything?”

“Truth spells.”

“Oh.”

“If someone doesn’t make good on your favor, all you have to do is go around telling people they’re a lying backstabber. No one will trust them, and your problem’s solved.”

“Something that can only work in a place where magic users are as common as dirt.”

Pisces looked approving. Calvaron grinned as he nodded.

“Of course, some people have more secrets to trade than others. Some people just use secrets when they have to—they trade gold for secrets, or get someone else to make all the trades for them. Like me.”

“You?”

“I’m a broker. I have a lot of secrets in my head, and even more that I don’t even know myself. Spelled parchment that erases itself when opened—that was popular a while ago. Messages in bottles, that sort of thing.”

Ceria eyed Calvaron slightly askance.

“And you trade secrets, is that it? If I have a juicy one, I can trade it to you for something else?”

“Anything you want to know. I accept all kinds of minor secrets; if you’ve got gold or gems I’ll take that too, but I prefer secrets.”

He grinned at both half-Elf and Human sitting at the table. After a second, the half-Elf rolled her eyes.

“This place gets weirder by the second. Okay, remind me to never ask you for a favor.”

“Aw, don’t be like that. Look, because we’re friends I’ll share a secret with you. On the house.”

Both Ceria and Pisces eyed Calvaron dubiously, the former with considerably more suspicion than the latter. Calvaron laughed lightly again. He looked around and muttered something—Ceria saw his fingertips flash for a second—before he spoke to them in a quiet voice.

“Here’s a free secret for you new students: most magic-based classes require at least ten levels in [Mage] to learn. A lot of them take at least twenty levels. That’s why most classes just teach the basics—they want you to have a high [Mage] level before you try to specialize.”

“Is that really true?”

Ceria wasn’t sure if she should be impressed or not. It was probably true, but was that really a secret worth trading?

“This would be a small secret, wouldn’t it?”

“Pretty small, unless you knew the exact requirements for a class. That would constitute a large secret.”

“And you’re just giving this one away because we’re friends, huh?”

“Just a sample. Now, if you want to know anything else, we can negotiate.”

Pisces frowned.

“That’s very mercenary of you.”

“Hey, we’ve all got to eat. And if I can build up a bit of credit on the side—”

“So you’re not going to tell us anything else unless we pay you.”

“That’s right.”

Ceria frowned.

“That’s not fair. Tell us at least one more secret—an obvious one.”

Calvaron raised his eyebrows, looking mildly exasperated.

“I just gave you a secret for free.”

“Yeah, a pretty useless one. We’ll get our classes no matter what happens—who cares about what’ll happen ten levels from now? Tell us something we can use in Wistram.”

She frowned at the Centaur and he frowned back, but he did seem to consider her suggestion. He nudged his friend gently in the side of her armor.

“I don’t know. Beatrice?”

She shrugged.

“Mushrooms.”

With a put-upon sigh, Calvaron nodded.

“Fine. Here’s another one, but this *is* the last secret. It’s about your books.”

“Our books?”

“You got new spellbooks on the first day, right? Come on, let’s see them.”

Reluctantly, Ceria and Pisces pulled out their spellbooks. They had indeed been issued mostly-empty books for apprentice mages. The first few pages had been filled with notes and spells in another person’s hand, but the majority was blank. Calvaron chuckled as he showed the students the empty pages.

“Thought so. Here’s something the academy does all the time. They take old books—the ones left behind by students—and give them to new students. You’ll never find anything beyond a Tier 2 spell in the spellbooks, because the older mages will sort through the lot to make sure they don’t give anything good to the new students.”

“Huh. So there are better spellbooks out there?”

Calvaron and Beatrice nodded.

“Yup. You’ll be able to read them as you rise in, well, status. You can take out books from the libraries, but only experienced students know where the good books are hidden.”

“And you would know where they’re kept, I presume?”

The Centaur raised his hands.

“Me? Perish the thought. If I could trade for that secret, I would. But the locations of the secret libraries and tomes are among the biggest secrets you can trade for.”

“And that’s your big secret. Again, it sounds more like something you could’ve just told us to be friendly.”

Ceria crossed her arms, annoyed and slightly disgusted. She saw Calvaron exchange an amused glance with Beatrice, and scowled fiercely.

“All of your ‘secrets’ sound pretty useless to me, Calvaron.”

“I don’t know about that.”

He avoided her gaze, an amused smile on his face as he snagged a slice of pork from her plate.

“All knowledge is useful to someone else. And there are secrets and *secrets*. For instance, the fact that Miss Springwalker here is a half-Elf? Not really a secret. But the knowledge that Pisces here has a rapier and a silver bell? That’s important knowledge. Someone might ask where he came from, knowing that.”

“How did you—?”

“And that this morning, Pisces managed to impress even Rievan during class? And that he didn’t like Miss Ceria?”

“Calvaron—”

The Centaur cut Ceria off. He looked directly at her.

“And of course, there’s your origins. The records are sealed of course, but anyone can look up old records. And half-Elves have long histories. In fact, if you looked back at certain Terandrian city arrest warrants, you could find a small bounty on a certain half-Elf kid for theft, property damage and —”

Ceria *slammed* her hands on the table, cutting the Centaur off. He stared at her surprised. She was shaking, and Ceria saw Beatrice grab Calvaron’s side warningly. But she didn’t say or do anything that would start something else. Without a word, she stood up and walked away. Calvaron called out after her, but Ceria ignored him. She stalked off, leaving her unfinished meal behind.

“Ceria? Ah! Ceria, please wait!”

She heard the voice calling out after her as she stomped away. At first Ceria just walked faster, but the voice kept shouting her name. In the end, she grudgingly slowed to let Pisces catch up.

“What?”

The young man slowed and panted—theatrically, Ceria thought—as he caught up with her. He smiled nervously as she glared at him.

“I ah, I just wanted to walk back with you.”

“Did you?”

“Well—”

Ceria started walking again, and Pisces hesitated before matching her pace.

“Calvaron is, uh, apologetic.”

“Good for him.”

She gritted her teeth. Pisces paused again before he adopted a placating tone.

“They were trying to help us, or so I feel. I understand that they went too far—”

“I came here to learn magic, not to find out secrets about other people and trade favors and gossip like a pack of simpering [Noblewomen].”

“As did I.”

Pisces took two strides forwards, and looked at Ceria. She glared at him, emotions running hot.

“What?”

“Nothing. I would just like to opine that, well, we are new to Wistram.”

“So?”

“So, rather than get too upset—why don’t you forget Calvaron’s transgression, and have a drink with me instead? It does no good to get too worked up right away, in my experience.”

“Oh really? Well, how much experience have you had?”

“None.”

Pisces grinned at her widely, and Ceria’s face went slack before she laughed unwillingly. The anger drained out of her as quick as it had come, leaving her feeling more than a little silly.

“Okay, okay. I should...rot, I should apologize to Calvaron. I didn’t mean to storm off like that. It’s just when he brought up my past—”

The young man interrupted with surprising tact.

“I shouldn’t worry about that. Calvaron feels he went too far. I think he’ll be the one apologizing when you two next meet. Until then, we should really have a drink.”

“A drink? Here? But they don’t serve free beer.”

If they did, Ceria would already have downed a few mugs to take the burden of the day away. But Pisces just gave her another smile.

“They do not. But there are places where it is sold, quite cheaply too. All one has to do is trade for the *secrets*...”

He wagged his eyebrows and Ceria snorted.

“Don’t tell me you traded Calvaron for one of his secrets.”

“Not as of such. I ah, may have told Calvaron that I would intercede on his behalf if he told us the best place in the isle to find alcohol, preferably for free. He informed me of a party that should be beginning tonight. Would you care to join me?”

Ceria thought about it, and then smiled slightly wickedly.

“You’re telling me you blackmailed Calvaron for free beer?”

“He’s not as good at negotiating as he thinks he is, and I do believe he wants to be friends.”

The two began to walk off in another direction. Ceria was smiling against her will and Pisces tried to tell jokes and speculated on what secrets might be worth trading for. She found herself answering back, wondering about the illusion and destruction magic classes, and before she knew it, they were talking again.

Just like on the boat. And best of all, she *hadn’t* made a scene—well, not that big of a scene—and ruined a potential friendship with Calvaron and Beatrice. And thanks to Pisces, she was going to be drunk, or at least tipsy tonight.

Pisces. Ceria glanced at him sideways as the mage tripped over his robes. He was coolheaded when she was not. And he had a quick tongue and a fast mind. He was also a talented [Mage]; in short, all the things that should have made him the competition for Ceria. But he was also friendly, and helpful. He seemed like a good...friend. A Human friend? Now, wasn’t that an odd thought.

A week later, Ceria had gotten used to Wistram’s quirks and peculiarities. She had gotten over the system of secrets, resigned herself to at least one class with a teacher who didn’t like her, and surprisingly enjoyed and learned quite a lot from all her classes. True, she wasn’t exactly learning how to cause earthquakes, but there was a whole basis of magic she had never understood until now. Maybe this was why Wistram Mages were always considered better than other mages; they might not be higher level, but they knew how spells *worked*.

The other thing that the half-Elf had learned after spending some time in Wistram was the architecture of the building. It really was simple, once you got over the varied passageways. There was a general, central area

containing dormitories, classrooms, general storage—everything a new student needed. Central hallways branched out or spiraled upwards leading to these individual sections, but the higher levels and the lower recesses of Wistram were off-limits.

There were actual magical barriers in some places, locked doors or Golems standing guard duty near stairwells in others. They were there to stop new students from going too high or too low, where more dangerous magical experiments still ran wild, and the most powerful of mages worked and lived. In short, that was where the real magic happened, but until she got to that point or even became a full student, Ceria was content just to find her way around.

And it was a good thing *she* could get to places on time, because Pisces certainly couldn't. The young man had to follow her to get to all their classes, and on a day like today where both of them were rushing, Ceria was just glad for his long legs.

"Are you *sure* this is the right way!"

"I'm positive! And if you'd bother to memorize the way to class, we wouldn't be late!"

Ceria snapped over her shoulder as she and Pisces ran down a corridor, running past a plodding Golem made of stone and amused older students who called out to them as they passed by. Pisces muttered as they rounded a corner and went straight down a seven-way intersection.

"Why don't they have *signs*?"

"Because that would make it too easy. And being a [Mage] is hard work. Come on, we're nearly there!"

"Why are we going to class? We just finished Rievan's lecture a half-hour ago!"

"I don't know! Cessic just told us to get to the classrooms."

"Cessic? You trusted him?"

"Has he ever lied?"

"Well—"

Cessic was another one of the new students Ceria and Pisces had gotten to know. He was a Lizardman, and as such, he'd naturally gravitated towards Ceria when they'd been in class together. The Humans—the overwhelming majority of new students—tended to stick together, and Ceria still felt a lurch of anger when she saw Charles and his group strutting

around their circle. But the non-Humans had their own cliques, and Ceria had sat next to Cessic more than once.

“Here we are!”

The two mages skidded to a halt and found a large group of students, both prospective and older ones—waiting outside of one of the classroom doors. Ceria blinked. This classroom she’d never been in, and she was fairly certain none of the teachers had used it before. She spotted a tall Lizardman with multicolored scales and edged over to him.

“Cessic! Hey, Cessic! What’s going on?”

Cessic turned his head and fanned his neck frills out slightly as he spotted Ceria and Pisces.

“There you two are! You’re just in time—I think we’re about to get our first class in destruction magic!”

“Really?”

“You’re kidding!”

The two mages stared at Cessic in disbelief. Although they’d taken quite a few classes, they still hadn’t managed to find the class that taught illusion magic (Pisces had suggested that such a class didn’t exist and it was a prank pulled on new students; Ceria had agreed), and as far as they’d known, the teacher in charge of teaching combat spells hadn’t shown up to any of her classes.

“How do you know?”

“Look around.”

Cessic pointed to the other students.

“Apparently, the Council—the leaders of all the mage factions in Wistram—chewed out the mage in charge of this class—told them to start teaching right away. I got the tip-off from Calvaron; he sold it to me cheap, since word spread so quick.”

“Of course he did.”

Ceria sighed, although she wasn’t actually that mad. She’d gotten used to Calvaron selling secrets, and she’d even bought two off him for small favors and secrets in return—one to find out where the bathrooms on her floor were, and another for a shortcut that saved her several minutes getting to the banquet hall each day. Apparently, a rather irate [Illusionist] had grown fed-up with waiting in line for the bathroom each day and enchanted her own private restroom, until word had spread of its existence.

“Who’s the mage? Are you sure they’re coming?”

“Fairly. I mean, if they didn’t offer the class they’d be punished, and I don’t think they’d want to risk—”

Cessic cut off and the hubbub around Ceria died. She looked and saw the door to the classroom slowly opening. She held her breath, not sure whom to expect. What she saw was a tall, older woman—perhaps in her late thirties—stepping out of the room. It was actually hard to place this Human’s age, because although her hair was slightly greying, she had no wrinkles. Her face was smooth and flawless so Ceria supposed her hair was just naturally grey. What the woman did give off though was an aura of cold, both in mannerism and temperature.

And Ceria recognized her, vaguely. She was the woman who’d cast [Ice Lance] on the first day at the Ghouls. She was...

“My name is Illphres. I specialize in ice magic, and I’m assigned to teach you all some spells to use in actual combat.”

The woman spoke abruptly and without any hint of welcome. She raised her voice so the silent students could all hear her. Ceria exchanged a glance with Pisces. This sounded like the introduction the other teachers had given a week ago! And why were they all here? Was she going to teach all the students at once?

Illphres’ eyes swept over the assembled students once. Then she spoke again.

“However, I don’t want to be a teacher. I was forced to take this job by the Council, even though I have better things to do. So I’m going to give you a test. Pass it and I’ll teach you magic.”

So saying, Illphres turned and pointed towards the open doorway.

“[Ice Wall].”

The students in the crowd stepped back as ice rose from the ground, forming out of the suddenly misty air and freezing into a thick, impenetrable wall that sealed off the entrance to the classroom. Ceria heard confused voices as she felt the temperature in the corridor drop so suddenly she shivered. People moved back in front of her, stepping away from the extreme cold.

Illphres didn’t seem bothered by the chill. She was wearing light robes, and she touched the ice as if it were just stone. But she had confidence in her spell as well, because her next words were a challenge.

“Melt the ice. Gain entry to the classroom and I will teach you. Do it yourselves, without an artifact or another mage to help you. That is all.”

Without another word she stepped aside. The students stared at her incredulously. So did Ceria.

“That’s it?”

One of the students, a young Drake, stepped forwards angrily. He pointed to the wall of ice.

“You expect us to melt through *that*? How? We came here to learn combat spells! Some of us don’t know any flame magic!”

“Not my problem.”

Illphres stood with her arms crossed, waiting for someone to make a move. Ceria hesitated. She knew her best flame spell, [Flame Jet], wasn’t nearly good enough to melt through a wall of ice. Maybe if she had time—

She was too busy staring at the wall to see another student stride up to Illphres angrily. He was corpulent—fat being too general a term. He was wearing robes and by the looks of him he was an older student, given that he was brave enough to call Illphres out to her face.

“This isn’t fair! We’re supposed to be taught by you unconditionally! You don’t get to impose a restriction like—”

He cut off sharply as the temperature around Illphres lowered. Ceria *felt* it lower from where she was standing; she saw the student’s robes suddenly frost over, and then he was stumbling away, sobbing, his clothing crackling with frost.

Illphres flicked a bit of frozen spittle off her robes as if nothing had happened. She spoke quietly, calmly to the other students.

“I’m allowed to test you. So I am. I don’t feel like teaching children who can barely cast [Light], so this is my condition. Pass it or fail; it matters little to me.”

“Fine then.”

Another student moved up. He was a Dullahan, and his fingers burned with flames as he put his head on his shoulders. He raised both his hands and aimed it straight at the wall of ice.

“*[Flaming Swathe]!*”

Ceria watched as a long stream of fire blew outwards from the mage’s palms, licking over the door and raising the temperature in the corridor several degrees. She exchanged a look with Pisces—he looked impressed as well. It was a [Flaming Swathe], a Tier 3 spell, but the student held it for over twenty seconds, which had to have taken quite a bit of mana.

When he eventually lowered his hands, the Dullahan was panting, sweat standing out on his head. He wiped it away with one gauntlet and smiled confidently as the smoke cleared. But then his face fell.

The barrier of ice stood in the doorway, not even slightly melted by the fire. Illphres shook her head as she looked dismissively at the older student.

“A Tier 3 spell. Not even a good one at that; if you want to clear snow, use that spell. For this, you’d better have something better.”

She stared at the panting Dullahan. He couldn’t meet her eyes as he stepped back. Illphres looked around.

“Anyone else want to try? No? Then I’m going.”

She began to walk away. Silence followed her footsteps. Ceria couldn’t believe what she was seeing. Before she knew it, she’d raised her voice.

“We came here to be mages!”

Ceria shouted it at Illphres’ back. She couldn’t help herself. She raised her voice in outrage as the woman turned and regarded her silently.

“If you don’t want to teach us, take it up with the Council! But we’ve just started learning, and we need help, not an impossible task!”

A few students around her raised their voices in agreement. More spoke up, and then they were all shouting at Illphres. The woman just stared at them all without expression. She didn’t smile or frown—she didn’t even blink. It wasn’t just having a still face; it was as if her own face was frozen in place. It was so unnerving that after a few seconds, the noise had faded from the hallways once again.

When Illphres spoke, it was in a flat voice as she met Ceria’s eyes.

“*Real* [Mages] don’t need help. They forge their own paths. If you want someone to hold your hand, find another teacher.”

She turned and walked away. Ceria clenched her fists, helpless, as the blurred shape of Illphres disappeared down the corridor. Pisces patted her on the shoulder, and Cessic said something Ceria didn’t quite catch.

Slowly, the students began trooping down the corridor, not saying much. But they paused when they saw a ten foot high wall of ice right as the corridor opened up into the intersection. The wall left a foot of room near the ceiling, but besides that it was impenetrable.

In consternation, the students stared at the wall of shimmering ice. One student disbelievably put their palm against it and found it stuck. As the shouting started, Ceria stared at the wall, and then at the mage standing at the far end of the intersection. It was hard to see the woman’s face through

the distorted ice, but Ceria could swear she was smiling slightly. Then she turned and walked away.

Pisces stared at the ice as Cessic and Ceria just stood there in silence. He looked at Ceria.

“...How are we supposed to get out?”

“We’re going to die here.”

Cessic made that announcement after twenty minutes had passed and the fifty-odd students had made no progress breaking down the wall of ice magic. Over half the students knew at least one flame-based spell, but no matter how they’d pooled their spells and attacked in unison, the icy barrier had resisted all the flames.

“It *has* to be a Skill! A normal [Ice Wall] spell would melt, however slowly. But this ice is practically resistant to flame!”

Pisces looked as happy as she did. Concerned, he stared at the ice. Ceria just glared. Her spells had washed right over the wall without doing anything to it; and none of the other students still blasting it with low-level spells were having any better luck.

They couldn’t touch the ice, either, or they’d risk getting stuck to it. Several students had already tried climbing the ice, but they’d stopped after leaving good bits of their skin on the frozen surface. Now, most of the students were just standing around and talking, waiting for a higher-level mage to come by and rescue them.

“We’re all going to die.”

The only problem was that some people couldn’t handle waiting. Cessic was pacing back and forth, hyperventilating as he panicked. Ceria sighed and edged away from him; the Lizardman was apparently claustrophobic, and he gave off fear that was starting to spread to some of the other new students.

“We’re not going to die, Cessic. Stop pacing. Just—stand over there and don’t look at the wall, okay? Look out one of the windows?”

“Do—do you think I could jump out of one?”

The Lizardman looked hopefully at one of the windows. Ceria shuddered and grabbed his tail.

“Don’t. It’s a long way down. Just wait, okay? Someone will melt the ice soon enough.”

“Okay. Okay. I’m going to...I’ll just put my head out the window.”

Cessic staggered away. Ceria and Pisces stared at him until they saw he was just looking out the windows rather than climbing out, and then they went back to sitting. In silence.

“I really don’t like her.”

“She does appear to have a most objectionable personality, doesn’t she?”

Pisces nodded to the other wall of ice blocking off the classroom. Ceria scowled and flicked a bit of dirt off the floor. She looked around and saw most of the other students were seated—save for a knot of furious students in robes. They were all older students, a group of five, the Dullahan, and the fat Human who’d gotten frosted by Illphres. They were talking fiercely, and Ceria couldn’t help but edge over a bit to listen.

“We’re third-year students! Illphres was supposed to teach us as well, but the woman doesn’t even respect other mages!”

The overly-pudgy mage was talking to the others angrily, and they were nodding as they stayed out of spit-range. The Dullahan was wearing a sour expression as he stared at the ice wall.

“If I had a Tier 4 spell, I could have melted that ice. I wish I could have wiped that smug expression off of her face.”

“Well, if you want to learn it, there’s always the book. If we could pay someone to get it for us, then—”

The older students looked around, and saw Pisces and Ceria standing not-too-subtly near them. They broke off immediately. After a second of scrutiny, one of them raised their voices.

“You two, you’re new students, aren’t you? Shame you got Illphres as a teacher.”

Ceria and Pisces walked over. The other students introduced themselves.

“I take it this isn’t what normal teachers do?”

“Hardly.”

The overweight student snorted. He gestured towards the classrooms.

“Last year we had *proper* teachers, but this year the Council decided to make the selection process random. Hah! This is what we get. It looks like

you two won't be learning any combat spells unless you pass your entrance test."

Dismayed, Pisces and Ceria exchanged a glance. The older students nodded in agreement. One of them grinned at the new students.

"Still getting to know the academy? I remember how confusing it was when I was a new student here."

"That's right. We still haven't found where the illusion class is being taught."

"Hah! Good luck with that. You could get the location from Calvaron, but he'll charge you an arm and a horse's leg for it."

The older students laughed again, but the Dullahan paused as he stared at Pisces.

"You're *that* Pisces, aren't you? If you trade me a rapier and a bell, I'll tell you where the illusion classes are being held."

"Ah."

Pisces blinked in surprise, and then smiled apologetically.

"Sorry, but my personal accoutrements are not for sale."

"Pity. Well, until we get this damn barrier melted, we'd best save our mana rather than waste it on this."

With a flick of the hand the Dullahan indicated the ice barrier. He jerked his head and the other students walked away, saying goodbye to Pisces and Ceria. They found a secluded part of the corridor and began to speak intently again, this time making sure no one was near them.

"That was an odd offer, don't you think?"

Pisces and Ceria stood in front of the ice wall, talking. Pisces nodded as he looked over to the other students.

"An offer to tell us where the illusion class was being taught for a duelist's, that is to say, my, bells. That was the most direct trade I've heard so far, I believe."

"Maybe you should have taken him up on the offer."

Ceria joked, but Pisces just shook his head. He was very intent as he studied the older students from the side.

"Did you notice his companion's expressions? They clearly didn't expect his ruse to succeed, once again adding to my theory that the illusion class is, in of itself, an illusion."

"Why offer if it wouldn't succeed, then?"

“For the bell. Another clue. If he wants that for simple directions—well, if the class were so easy to find, it would be a very one-sided deal.”

Ceria raised her eyebrows.

“It’s that valuable? That little bell?”

“It is, to some at least. I—”

The young man broke off, shaking his head. Ceria knew he didn’t want to talk about his past, and let the matter drop. Instead, she perked up her pointed ears, trying to listen to what the students were saying. She caught only a fraction as the conversation from other students entered a temporary lull.

“...spell book. I’m *sure* it has at least one Tier 4 spell in it, but the protections—”

Then the babble rose and Ceria lost the thread. She sighed. More secrets, and this one sounded promising. A spellbook?

Pisces was looking repeatedly over to the group of students as well. Ceria saw him tap his lips thoughtfully, but he didn’t make a move to sidle over. She thought she saw him whisper something, but it might have just been a trick of the light.

As Ceria turned to check on Cessic, she saw a dark shape flit towards the older students. She turned back quickly, but whatever it was had gone the instant she looked.

“See something?”

She shook her head at Pisces and made a face.

“Great. There are *rats* trapped in here with us.”

“Rats? Are you sure?”

Cessic said that, coming over from the window to rejoin the other two. Pisces frowned as he looked around, and Ceria did too, although she couldn’t spot the dark shape.

“Either that or some large bug.”

“I wouldn’t mind a bug or a rat if that’s all we’ll be eating. You know, I skipped lunch for this.”

The Lizard moaned as he rubbed his stomach. Ceria was about to tell him to suck it up or go searching for the creature in question when Pisces suddenly called out.

“Hello? Is anyone there? We’re trapped here; we could use some help!”

Ceria turned and saw a tall figure through the distorted ice. It stopped and walked over towards them. Ceria held her breath as she saw a porcelain

face, and saw the seven foot tall creation move as gracefully as a dancer. She heard Cessic gulp and the other students go quiet.

Pisces smiled in relief at the stone woman who looked as though she had traded stone for flesh. Cognita's smooth face smiled slightly as she looked down at them.

"You are Cognita, yes? I hesitate to ask, but we've found ourselves trapped, you see. A [Mage] made this barrier and we can't break through it."

The Truestone Construct, the Golem who acted like a person, nodded. She regarded the ice wall as if she was staring at a speck of dust as she spoke.

"Ah. This is the work of Illphres. Stand back please, and employ any protective spells you know. I will remove this barrier."

So saying, she let the students scurry backwards twenty feet before she lifted one delicate arm. Her dress rippled as her stone fist casually *punched* straight through the wall of ice with an impact that sounded like an avalanche.

Ceria and Pisces gaped as bits of ice showered down around Cognita. She raised her hand and punched twice more, and the wall collapsed. With ease, the Golem kicked the ice fragments aside and nodded to the students.

"The path is clear. I will have the rest disposed of soon enough, although the binding spell has already been broken."

She nodded politely at Pisces and walked away. In silence, the students watched her go. After a minute, they began to file out, avoiding the jagged bits of ice.

Cessic paused after he'd cleared the broken ice wall. He put one hand against the stone wall, looking pale.

"I think I need to go have a lie down."

Ceria and Pisces agreed with the sentiment, even if they weren't so ill as Cessic. They slowly began to walk towards their rooms. Ceria stared at the broken ice, and wondered if she'd ever be able to match any of the beings who walked these halls.

The two mages were tired after their small adventure, so they had agreed to take a brief rest before going to dinner. Ceria wanted to have a

drink to wash away the stress, so they had agreed to find another party afterwards.

The funny thing about Wistram was that while all the mages studied magic, there was always at least one mage *not* studying and instead imbibing as much alcohol as possible. Something about rigorous and intense concentration brought it out in people, and the new students were only too happy to drink as much free liquor as possible until someone started throwing spells around.

But there was nothing in Ceria that really wanted to have a drink and relax. She stomped into her room, teeth clenched. She'd been in a bad mood all day, ever since she'd met Illphres. Now that she was alone, Ceria could give vent to her feelings at last.

"Aargh!"

She *screamed* as loudly as she could in her locked room. Ceria hurled her possessions around and then raised her finger and started shooting [Stone Dart] at one of the walls.

"That stupid—arrogant—mold-headed, sun-baked piece of tree fertilizer! That inbred—"

Shards of stone broke as the rapid stone missiles shattered against the enchanted stone. Ceria felt some fragments strike her and stopped as one cut her.

"Ow! *Damn it!*"

That just made her madder. She punched the bed, and then started ripping the covers and pillows off and stomping on them.

"Real mages? *Real mages?* I'll show her a real mage! I'll—"

She began kicking everything on the floor before she moved on to punching her bed and then a wall. Ceria let out her aggression on anything in sight—she normally found a quiet bit of forest to raise hell in when she was angry, but Wistram was extremely forest-deficient.

She'd always had a temper. As a child, Ceria could remember getting angry enough to burst and then chasing woodland animals around, punching foxes, biting sticks in half—

"Ceria? Ceria, are you okay? I hear noises."

Ceria looked up, part of her pillow in her mouth. She spat out the feathers and called out, somewhat sheepishly.

"I'm—fine, Pisces. Sorry."

"Ah, do you want to talk?"

“Um—”

A few minutes later, Ceria edged out of her doorway. Pisces only caught a glimpse of floating feathers and a very ransacked room before she practically chased him back into his room.

“Sorry about that. Did you hear—much?”

“Not in so many words. Just...noise. I was concerned.”

Pieces offered Ceria his bed, since he only had one chair. She sat on it, and looked around. His room was different than hers; he had a large bed and an actual balcony on his, but besides that his room was very clear—almost austere. His rapier sat in one corner and Pisces had a few clothes in a pile on one side of the room, and nothing else.

“Nice room.”

“I shall take that in the spirit it was intended. I ah, notice you redecorated yours just now.”

Ceria grinned sheepishly.

“Sorry. Was I that loud?”

“Allow me to say it this way: you were audible through the stone. Was that ice mage that upsetting to you?”

The half-Elf shrugged, turning a bit red.

“It’s—okay, yes, she was. But it’s not just that. It’s just—I thought when I got here things would be different. I thought I’d learn magic, not get involved in petty...*politics*.”

“I must confess, our entry here has been a bit different than what I expected.”

Pisces murmured as he sat next to Ceria. She flicked a feather out of her hair and laughed softly.

“I guess. I shouldn’t be surprised. But doesn’t it feel like we’re not learning everything we could be? I mean, our basic magic classes are fine, but without combat magic—learning that was the entire reason I came here.”

“Mm.”

Pisces nodded, his expression troubled. Ceria let out her breath, giving vent to more of her hitherto unspoken worries.

“And we don’t have that much *time*, Pisces! If we had a year—or even half of one I could relax. I could prove myself but we have *one month*. And I don’t know what their exams are, but I can’t just believe they’ll take me

because I know a few spells and I'm a half-Elf. I have to be a student here and I just don't have anything special to offer."

"Neither do I."

"Oh come on. You're the best in our class at our lessons."

"Best in a class full of new students. That is hardly a ringing endorsement."

"...True."

Both students sat together gloomily. Ceria rested her head in her hands, wishing she'd had a real book of spells to study, or that she'd apprenticed under the half-Elf spellcasters back in her village. Pisces sat in his chair, head bowed, apparently lost in thought. Then he slowly raised his head and spoke in a low voice.

"What if there was something we could do?"

"What?"

Ceria looked at him. Pisces' expression was unreadable, but his fingers twitched and his foot jiggled with nerves. He looked at Ceria and licked his lips.

"I uh, well, you know when we were listening to those older students talk? Before they spoke to us, one of them mentioned a spellbook in conjunction with a Tier 4 spell."

"I remember that."

Ceria frowned as she remembered.

"Yeah, they said that. But so what? If they've got one—"

"Ah, but they don't. Have one, that is."

Pisces raised a finger as Ceria stared at him. He licked his lips again.

"I—happened to overhear the rest of their conversation."

"How? With a spell?"

Ceria looked at him in disbelief. Her ears were far better than any Human's and she'd been standing right next to Pisces. He hesitated.

"Something like that. A spell, yes. I'd prefer not to say."

"Okay."

Pisces was acting oddly, but Ceria was intrigued now. She scooted over on his bed as he lowered his voice again. No one could hear them in the room, but both felt the need to be secretive.

"I heard the rest of their conversation. They were talking about a spellbook, yes. A book they do not have. There is a book in a hidden part of the library—in a secret section. The students have located it and they are

sure it has potent spells, but the book is warded. If they try to take it, it will kill them.”

“Yikes.”

Ceria’s hair rose at the thought. A trapped book? Wistram had more than one library section, but all the books she’d found were normal books or the lowest-level spellbooks full of cantrips. No wonder the other sections were secret if the books had wards like that.

Pisces nodded.

“I also...happened to overhear where the section is, and how to get in. We could gain access to that section.”

“And look around for other spellbooks?”

Ceria’s heart lifted at the thought. But then she thought of the dangers and hesitated. And Pisces was shaking his head.

“Not just that. If we gain access to the library, too many things could go wrong. We aren’t allowed to read higher level spells as new students, and besides, there could be more warding spells. But if we could somehow obtain that particular book they were talking about—”

“You mean steal?”

The half-Elf looked at Pisces in disbelief. His lack of a response was her answer.

“I have a plan. I hesitate to carry it out, but I am sure it would work. I just don’t know whether I should try.”

“It is stealing after all.”

“True, but—it is not as if these students own that book. It is in the library, for anyone to take.”

Ceria slowly let out her breath. Something was tickling her stomach, the same feeling she’d felt back when she was younger.

“Anyone with the courage. And the intelligence to get it without dying.”

“Precisely. It may not be safe. And if we are caught—well, I doubt we will get into that much trouble. But there is danger, especially if the other students find us as we are retrieving the book.”

“And getting it in the first place.”

“Yes.”

Pisces waited. Ceria considered their options, and then shook her head. But not to say no.

“The way I see it...we’ve only got a month—three weeks, really. We can either play the good students, or we can take a risk.”

The young man's eyes gleamed with excitement as the half-Elf smiled at him, showing teeth. He reached out a hand and Ceria took it.

"Tonight?"

"I believe so. If we wait, the other students may attempt to retrieve it earlier. And I can execute my plan quickly. We just need time, and the right moment when no one is around."

"Okay then. What if we—"

Ceria turned her head, and paused as she saw an irregularity out of the corner of her eyes. She turned her head.

Something moved in the corner of Pisces' room, by the dresser. Ceria sat up instantly. She only saw a flash of grey fur before the creature darted back out of sight.

"There's rats *everywhere!*"

She stood up, annoyed more than she was upset. She'd eaten rats before, but she didn't *like* the disgusting things. She went to the dresser, but Pisces stopped her.

"No need."

"Oh come on. Where there's one there could be a dozen. We need to destroy the nest before—"

"I have taken care of it. Don't worry, Ceria. We have more important things to do."

She blinked.

"Oh. You got them?"

"Ah, yes. I had a small infestation of mice in my room. This one must be a straggler."

"Had?"

Pisces blinked.

"Have. Excuse me. I must have neglected to round up all of the vermin in my last sweep. It should be of no consequence."

Ceria hesitated. She pointed to the dresser.

"Are you sure? One [Flame Jet] and they're cooked. It'll smell bad for a while, but—"

"I'm sure. I have my own methods of disposing of such creatures, and we mustn't waste time. Let us go to dinner, and then we'll begin the plan."

He ushered her towards the door. Ceria nodded reluctantly, but she stopped Pisces as he closed the door to get ready.

“Just be sure it isn’t a rat. Mice will leave you alone, but some of the nastier kinds of rats will nibble your nose off as you sleep.”

“I have everything under control.”

Pisces shut the door as Ceria went back into her room to clean up in the few minutes before they left to eat. He breathed a sigh of relief, and then scowled as a small shape slowly climbed up his dresser.

He stared at it. The ‘rat’ stared back with hollow, unblinking eyes. It was no rat. It was a mouse. And it was dead.

Pisces raised a finger, and the mouse scurried over to him. He carefully picked it up and tucked it into the pocket of his robe. And then he opened the door and walked into the corridor.

“Ceria? Are you ready?”

“Coming—just got to stuff the feathers back in here.”

Ceria emerged from her room, blowing away some more feathers. She smiled at Pisces and his heart skipped a beat.

“Ready?”

“To dinner, then. And afterwards...”

“Let’s go grab a spellbook.”

Wistram Days (Pt.3)

The stone halls were dark at night in Wistram. True, the mage-lights provided decent illumination, but the magics that controlled them dimmed the intensity of light that each floating orb of light or eternally burning torch gave off.

Many mages didn't care to wander outside of the thick walls that made up the citadel that was Wistram academy. Thus, this change in ambient light was the only clue some had that it was time to sleep. In parts of the citadel where there were no windows, mages could wander for hours without ever seeing the sun.

"I hear it's dimensional magic. Very complex stuff. I wonder how big Wistram really is. Has anyone ever tried to measure it from the inside and compared it to the outside?"

"Shut up!"

Most mages preferred to walk the halls at night with orbs created by the [Light] spell. However, the two new students who crept from shadow to shadow used no magic now. They were trying to be quiet.

And failing.

"I'm just saying, who created this place? It had to be an [Archmage], but how many additions were made over the years?"

"Pisces, for the love of *leaves*, shut up!"

The half-Elf in front snapped at the young man creeping along behind her. Pisces closed his mouth, and she prayed he'd keep quiet.

"Are you sure we're going the right way? I thought we should have gone left back there."

Ceria *hissed* with annoyance and straightened up. She paused in the shadows between two globes of light and looked around to make sure no one was walking down the corridors.

There wasn't anyone. They were safe. Mages did like to stay up at odd hours, it was true, but this wasn't a particularly well-travelled part of the academy in the day. Most students up this late would be drinking or having a party elsewhere. As for the mages, they'd be studying books, or doing the same thing as the students.

Still, Ceria lowered her voice as she spoke to Pisces.

“We’re trying to be stealthy here, don’t you get it? And the oval library with the staircase is this way, I’m sure of it!”

Pisces frowned, but Ceria knew her sense of direction was better than his. Wistram was confusing, but she’d gotten used to wandering around forests where every tree looked like the last one.

To his credit, Pisces kept his voice low, but he still kept chattering. Both he and she were nervous, and so he kept talking while she led them onwards.

“I don’t see why we’re hiding. It’s not as if we’re doing anything wrong.”

“We’re going to steal a book from other students. And we’re going to one of the restricted libraries to do it!”

“Well...it’s not their book.”

Ceria knew what she was doing might well get them kicked out of Wistram. But she was sick of sticking to the rules. She’d had to deal with Rievan, the rude, arrogant Human teacher who seemed to hate half-Elves, and Illphres, who had refused to teach them magic. She hated Wistram’s stupid secrets and the way everything was give and take around here.

And she was afraid she would fail the exam that was only a couple of weeks away. So Ceria had decided to break the rules and help Pisces steal the magical spellbook.

“They didn’t *expressly* forbid us from entering this section of the academy.”

Ceria frowned at Pisces.

“They told us this place was off-limits!”

“Ah. Yes. Well, I believe that may have been a warning rather than an inviolable rule. From all we’ve seen, I surmise that these restrictions are meant to test how we react to such impositions, not actually stop all of us.”

“What? Stop using complex words!”

Pisces paused. He chewed at his lip and rephrased his statement.

“We can break the rules—if we’re not caught. They’re expecting us to.”

“Oh. Right.”

Ceria thought about that and nodded.

“Makes sense. Okay, let’s get in there. Why couldn’t you have just said that from the start? You always use too many complicated words!”

“But I *like* complicated words.”

Pisces muttered as he and Ceria snuck down the empty side-corridor. She knew he was right, at least in a sense. It didn't seem like Wistram had many totally absolute rules. But still, she had to point out a flaw in his reasoning.

"The problem isn't whether we'll be caught by other mages and get punished. It's whether anyone sees us and sells someone else the secret that we were sneaking about right before a spellbook got stolen."

"Ah yes. Secrets. That would be problematic."

Behind Ceria, Pisces grimaced. Here in Wistram everyone's actions and words were carefully noted by people around them, to be used and traded like currency. Secrets were the lifeblood of the mages here, and it meant their presence in this part of the academy would be noted by anyone they met.

Ceria peeked around an intersection and then moved down it when she saw no one was there. She glanced up at a painting on the wall—some relief showing a bunch of adventurers battling a Goblin Lord. That meant they were close.

"You're sure the other students aren't going to try and grab the book tonight?"

"They said they were going to talk to another mage who specialized in dispelling wards. I think we're safe. The magic killed or nearly killed one of their friends. I don't think they'll be too eager to try again without preparation."

Ceria stopped. She turned to look at Pisces. He was nervous, but his pale face also looked excited. She was less sanguine.

"One of them got *killed*? Are you sure this plan of yours will work?"

He hesitated.

"Fairly. I believe there will be no risk to either one of us, even if it fails. The only thing we have to fear is being seen."

The half-Elf shook her head.

"I wish you'd explain."

"Too many ears back in the banquet hall. And I'm still not sure the older students don't place eavesdropping spells in the hallways. I can tell you now if you want, but it's faster this way."

"Tell me later, then. We're close."

The two moved onwards. Ceria knew her footsteps were almost inaudible, but Pisces shuffled around a bit in his cheap robes. Still, she

didn't expect anyone but another half-Elf or a species with good hearing to pick up on the faint sounds.

"How did you know what they were saying, anyways? Do *you* know a listening spell?"

She had to ask. Pisces hesitated. When he spoke quietly, his voice seemed uncertain.

"Something...similar. Suffice it to say I heard every word they spoke. Now...is this it?"

They'd reached a pair of double doors, set right next to a diagonal intersection of three corridors. Ceria stared at the doors and then at the way the wall ended a few feet ahead of the doors. Architecture and the laws of space didn't seem to matter in this place.

"This is it. Keep an eye out and make sure no one's coming."

Pisces nodded and looked around while Ceria put her ear to the door. She knew the room beyond the doors was large, but she listened hard for any sounds of people moving about. After a minute she'd still heard not a sound. Satisfied the room was probably empty, Ceria opened the door and she and Pisces slipped inside.

The oval library with the staircase was one of a multitude of libraries in Wistram. Most contained books, as befitted libraries, but some were dedicated to one subject, or all comprised of books from a certain era. One library had a pool of water in it, and all the books were waterproofed to let mages read and bathe.

Wistram was very odd. But this library was fairly normal, as libraries went. The room was indeed ovoid, and a central staircase led up to four walkways around the room where shelves of books sat side by side.

Ceria had never seen so many books before coming here. This place alone easily held a fortune in old, sometimes cracking books of dust and ink. She coughed and Pisces sneezed as they walked into the room.

"Rot. Golems haven't dusted in here for a while."

Pisces nodded. Eyes watering he sniffed and pointed.

"Too many...books. Ah, but look. You can see someone's been here."

Indeed, Ceria could see places where the dust had been disturbed. She and Pisces made their way up the staircase, following the cleared areas and found themselves on the second level, staring at a wall of books.

"Is there some kind of mechanism here? Some activated spell?"

"I think so. But let me see...hey, these are all real books!"

Pisces pulled a few tomes out of the shelves. Ceria stared at them. It looked like this entire shelf was dedicated to Human history. She spied different genealogies, historical accounts, and personal bibliographies, all from Human kingdoms she'd never heard of before. She frowned at Pisces as he flipped open a book and stared at the writing inside.

"They're real, yes. So what?"

"Well, apparently if you do this—"

Pisces pulled one of the books from the shelves and switched it with another book higher up. The instant the two books had been pushed into place, the entire bookshelf suddenly *faded*. Ceria gasped, and Pisces whistled quietly.

"Truly impressive. They're books that were all spelled with the same enchantment."

He waved a hand, letting it pass straight through the bookshelf. Ceria stared through the intangible books. There was a tunnel in the wall, one that leads straight into another room.

"A second library?"

"Yes. That's where we'll find the spellbook."

The two students stepped into the secret tunnel cautiously. Ceria gasped as she looked around the circular room occupied by a shelf full of books, and of all things, a bed and dresser! There was a small table and mirror which were both covered with dust.

Pisces sneezed and raised a small cloud of dust, and Ceria coughed and wiped at her eyes.

"Dead gods. Is this some secret bedroom?"

"Looks like it."

"Who'd make a secret passageway into a *library* of all places?"

"Someone who values their privacy?"

Pisces sidled away as Ceria kicked at him.

"Or someone who likes books. Or..."

"Or?"

He nodded towards the passageway that led back to the main part of the library.

"Or perhaps this library was ideal for whomever lived here. Most of the books seem to be largely historical in this section. Few people would bother to peruse the stacks. So whoever lived here might have constructed this

hiding place in a time when the mages of Wistram were less...amiable towards each other than they are now.”

Ceria shivered at that thought. She imagined mages fighting each other, sneaking about in hidden passages like this.

“You’ve got a twisted imagination Pisces, you know that, right?”

He shrugged self-consciously.

“I prefer to think of myself as pragmatic. Now...my plan should be working as we speak. We just need to find the book.”

“Shouldn’t be too hard.”

Ceria walked over to the bookshelf.

“Ah—don’t touch any of them!”

Pisces cautioned Ceria as she reached for a book. She snatched her hand back.

“What? I thought the books were spelled against opening.”

All the spellbooks she’d heard of were warded against being read, but Pisces shook his head.

“The one we’re after apparently killed the student who tried to take it out. And we cannot be sure the other ones aren’t trapped in the same way.”

“Dead *gods*. Who’s so paranoid they’d use a spell like that?”

Ceria groused as she and Pisces studied the books on the shelf at a respectful distance. It wasn’t too hard, just difficult to see the covers with all the dust clinging to the books. Pisces suggested blowing it away with a spell, and after that it was much easier.

“I’m assuming this is a personal spellbook, right?”

“Correct. There should be no title on the spine. And if we use [Detect Magic]...aha! These two books seem to be the most powerful.”

Pisces pointed to two of the tomes. One was thick and it looked to Ceria’s untrained eye like the spell on it wasn’t that powerful. She guessed it was just a valuable book of some kind, warded against tearing or decay. But the other book shone in her vision, not brightly, but with an intensity that made it seem *realer* than the other books in the room.

“That’s the one. I’m sure of it.”

“I think so too. Now, what was your big plan? Pry it out with something? A pair of sticks, maybe?”

“Don’t be silly. The spell might activate! No, we just have to wait—”

“Hold it!”

Ceria held up one hand, suddenly alarmed. Her ears twitched and she put a finger to her lips. Pisces went still and Ceria crept back towards the entrance of the tunnel. She whispered to Pisces.

“I hear footsteps.”

They must have been loud, for her to hear them. Ceria held her breath as she realized someone was definitely coming towards this very library. She looked at Pisces, suddenly worried.

“The students?”

“No—I think it might be someone else. If it’s who I think it is—”

“Who?”

Pisces opened his mouth, but the door opened before he could tell Ceria. She flinched back into the tunnel, realizing too late that they’d left the transparent bookshelf! Anyone would be able to see something was odd in an instant.

But the being that walked through the doorway was no mage, and certainly no student come to take the spellbook. A tall, inhumanly perfect woman made of grey stone seemed to glide through the doorway. She was eight feet tall and the stone clothing she wore rippled as she walked, as if she was alive.

Cognita turned and stared around the room. Her eyes found Ceria, hiding behind the transparent bookshelf, at once. The half-Elf jumped and shuddered, but Cognita just strode towards her with the same look of calm on her face as always.

“Ceria Springwalker. I hope you are having a good night?”

“What? Um, yes. Yes, I am. Cognita. Uh—”

Ceria stammered and took a step back as the Truestone Golem stopped in front of her. She was enormous. Ceria had no idea why she was here, but Pisces stepped forwards and Cognita’s head nodded fractionally.

“I have just received your note, student Pisces. May I ask what is the matter?”

The young man coughed and stood a bit straighter as Ceria’s head turned from him to Cognita rapidly.

“Yes, thank you Miss Cognita. I was hoping you could help me retrieve a book, you see. It’s warded with some kind of spell, but I would like to study it to advance my grasp of spellcraft.”

“I see.”

Cognita's face changed slightly as she stared down at Pisces. Ceria saw something shift in the Golem's usually impassive features. Was it curiosity? Then the eyes shifted to Ceria and the half-Elf felt a jolt in her stomach.

"I assume your friend is here for the same reason?"

"Ceria? Yes, she's just here for ah, moral support. The book is this way. If you would..."

Pisces gestured, and Cognita stepped forwards. He smiled up at her, letting the tall Golem bow her head to enter the tunnel. He would have followed, but Ceria pulled him back and hissed at him.

"You called *Cognita*? That was your plan?"

Pisces looked blankly at her.

"What's the problem with that?"

"Well..."

Ceria spluttered, unable to explain. How could she convey the unease she felt when she looked at Cognita, or rather, felt the Golem's eyes on her?

The eyes of the Truestone Golem had been sculpted to perfectly mimic the eyes of a Human woman. But they were not alive. They moved as if they were, though, and Ceria knew there was some intelligence controlling the thing that called herself Cognita. But it was not the same as living and it scared Ceria.

She knew other students in Wistram felt the same or more strongly. Some mages avoided Cognita in the hallways. Ceria could get along with the Golem because she was helpful and acted quite normally, but she didn't like Cognita's eyes.

Pisces however acted as though Cognita was no different than Ceria. He walked after her as the Golem studied the shelves and looked around the room.

"You see Cognita, we ah, happened to learn about this room you see, and I note that its previous occupant is probably long since deceased..."

"Yes."

Cognita nodded once and looked back at the two students.

"This is the residence of Nemistra Verdinan, a Selphid who lived here for many years in hiding. She is long dead, but it is good to see her room has finally been discovered. I will have other Golems collect the lost books and return them to their proper locations."

Both mages blinked up at Cognita, caught off-guard by the matter-of-fact response. Pisces coughed.

“Yes, well, I am, ah, glad. But could I trouble you to ask whether taking her former spellbook would be permissible? It’s the one on the second shelf from the bottom you see—”

“Yes. I see it.”

Cognita studied the tome, eyes unblinking. Ceria and Pisces held their breaths. When the Truestone Golem turned, she nodded again.

“The tome is guarded by several wards that would melt the flesh of anyone attempting to retrieve it. I can remove it without issue to myself, following which the wards would be broken.”

“Excellent!”

Pisces rubbed his hands together happily, but Ceria was uneasy.

“So you’ll just give us the book? Really?”

Cognita paused.

“That is acceptable. However, Wistram law now dictates that mages below the third year only be allowed one personal spellbook for their use. You have already been issued one. If I give you this book, you must return your spellbook.”

Ceria groaned. Of course. There *had* to be a catch. But Pisces was undeterred.

“Very well, Miss Cognita. I would happily trade in my spellbook for this one. Would you ah, like me to retrieve it before...?”

“No need.”

The Truestone Golem turned, and the stone woman calmly pulled the book out of the bookcase. Ceria held her breath, expecting something dramatic to happen. But all she saw was a slight ripple in the air as Cognita pulled the book out—then she calmly turned and held it out to Pisces.

He was reluctant to take it. Pisces’ hands trembled a bit as he reached for the book, and Ceria saw him visibly brace himself. But when he gingerly grasped the book and Cognita let go, nothing happened to him either. He nearly dropped the book in surprise.

“The wards have been broken. It is safe to read.”

“Many thanks!”

Pisces stared delightedly at the spellbook in his hands. He beamed at Cognita.

“I cannot thank you enough. Please, accept my profuse gratitude for your help rendered in—”

Ceria kicked Pisces in the shins. He yelped, but she just smiled at Cognita.

“Um, thank you Cognita. This was a big help. We couldn’t have gotten the spellbook alone.”

“No. You could not.”

Cognita’s eyes found Ceria’s, and the half-Elf saw only cold marble there. But there was something in Cognita’s tone that suggested the Golem understood what she’d done. And she’d done it anyways, knowing it would help Ceria and Pisces.

“Most mages would not have turned to me for help. Your decision to do so is interesting.”

Ceria had no idea what to make of *that*. She cleared her throat nervously.

“Um, well, Cognita, about this. We’d prefer to keep this secret—would you mind not telling anyone you helped us?”

Both she and Pisces held their breaths as the Golem pondered for a moment. Cognita shook her head.

“I care little for squabbles between mages. I am bound to be truthful, so I shall be. Thus, I shall relate all I have seen here.”

Ceria closed her eyes and Pisces groaned aloud. Cognita continued calmly.

“If I am asked about these specific events, I will share what I have seen. But only then. I suspect your secret will be safe, young mages.”

She nodded at Ceria and Pisces. The half-Elf and young man saw the Golem’s lips curve upwards slightly, and then the Golem turned.

“I must be going. I have other duties. I am pleased to have been of assistance to the two of you tonight. Sleep well.”

She walked away quickly, leaving Ceria and Pisces at a loss for words. They stared at her back, and then jumped as the Golem closed the double doors with a *click*. Ceria immediately began hurrying towards the doors, but Pisces called her back.

“Wait! We’ve got to cover our tracks! Let’s get this bookshelf back the way it was.”

“How?”

“I think we just replace the two books in their original positions.”

Sure enough, the instant the two books were in the right spot, the bookshelf became real again. Ceria and Pisces pressed on the books and

shelf, but it refused to budge.

“Impressive magic.”

“Admire it later! Let’s go before someone sees us!”

The two hurried out of the library, closing the door securely and moving quickly back towards their rooms. On the way, Ceria questioned Pisces, who was trying to walk and stare at the pages of the spellbook at the same time.

“That was—did you *know* Cognita could do that?”

“I had an inkling after she shattered that ice wall. If she can break Illphres’ enchantments, why not the trap spells on a book? And it seemed easy enough to ask her for help. After all, the Golems of Wistram are bound to help the students, are they not?”

Ceria had to agree with that, although she would have never considered the idea. She doubted the older students would have either. She frowned as she led Pisces down a passage and flight of steps.

“How did you send Cognita a note?”

“Secret.”

He grinned at Ceria impishly. She glared at him and he raised his hands.

“Really, it is a secret Ceria. I...it’s rather complicated. I’m sorry.”

She frowned, but let the matter drop. Soon, they were back in Pisces’ room and only then did Pisces open the spellbook on his table and let Ceria peer at it.

“Dead gods. Look at all the spells!”

Pisces had a wild grin on his face as he and Ceria flipped through page after page of uneven handwriting. Whoever had written the book had done it in a foreign language, but the nature of the magic spells was something any mage could decode with enough effort.

“I can’t understand what that spell does. Do you see...?”

“No. But I’m sure it will come in time. And look! This is clearly some kind of flame-based spell. Can’t you tell from the way it’s formed here?”

“You’re right!”

Ceria was giddy with excitement. They had a spellbook! A real spellbook, not one filled with useless spells! Her excitement faded a bit as she realized it really wasn’t *her* spellbook, though.

“I guess you’ll be able to learn a lot, huh?”

“What do you mean?”

Pisces turned to Ceria in surprise. He held the book to her.

“This was a joint effort, Ceria. This book is as much yours as it is mine. We can take turns reading it—”

“No, it’s yours. You didn’t need me at all! You could have done all of this by yourself!”

Pisces shook his head, offering the book to Ceria as she backed away.

“Not true. Your expertise in subversion and stealth were quite essential. And the addition of another pair of eyes and another mind to cross-check my conclusions were invaluable.”

“What does that—”

“Look, we worked on it together. And I want you to study it as well. If we can learn some spells from this, we might stand a good chance of passing the exams at the end of the month! This is an opportunity for both of us, Ceria.”

Slowly, it began to dawn on Ceria that Pisces had intended to share the book with her the instant he’d figured out how to take it. She looked at him awkwardly, not sure what to say.

He was a Human, but he was genuine and clearly wanted to help her pass. She smiled at him, and Pisces grinned back in delight.

“Well—okay. We can study together. Two arrows are better than one. But it’s your book, okay? After all, you’re going to have to give Cognita your other spellbook.”

“True. I’d better pretend I lost the other one.”

Pisces nodded at Ceria. But then he smiled widely again, overcome with delight.

“Let’s see how many spells we can identify! I’m sure there’s at least one Tier 4 spell in here!”

The two got back to poring over the book. Ceria squinted at the magical writing, guessing some of the spells with Pisces.

“Hey. Isn’t that...[Stone Fist]? That’s a good Tier 3 spell!”

“Really? I thought it was Tier 2?”

“I think it’s Tier 3. You see, when you use it you create this rock armor around your hand.”

“Isn’t that really heavy?”

“You’d think so, but I saw a [Druid] using it once. He cracked a boulder like it was nothing!”

“I bet we could learn that in time for the exam. What do you think?”

“Maybe. But look here. This is some kind of movement spell, I’m positive of it! Can you see what the nature of it is?”

Ceria bent forwards to look at the spell Pisces had pointed to. In doing so, she realized that she was sitting in a room in the middle of the night. With a young Human man.

A few years ago—she would have put an arrow in Pisces’ head, or run away. But now she was sitting next to him as if it was the most natural thing in the world. Ceria paused.

He was a good person, albeit a bit clumsy and wordy. But she liked him, and thought of him as a friend already. In fact, she quite liked him. Ceria had no idea how she felt about that.

The next day, Ceria had trouble keeping her eyes open in all of her classes. She was exhausted from staying up and trying to puzzle out the spells in Pisces’ book. She nearly fell asleep twice in her class studying basic enchantments and how to decode magical auras, but she didn’t dare close her eyes in Rievan’s class.

“I trust you’ve all memorized the lessons from yesterday?”

He stared around the classroom, staring at each student in turn. When he met Ceria’s eyes Rievan’s nose wrinkled slightly and he looked past her. He pointed.

“You there. Pisces. Where is your spellbook?”

Pisces jerked upright, blinking rapidly.

“My spellbook?”

“Yes! Where are your notes?”

Pisces folded his fingers together as Ceria tried not to stare at him.

“I lost my spellbook, sir. But I can recall my notes from last class quite well.”

“Really?”

One of Rievan’s narrow eyebrows rose as he glared at Pisces.

“Then you will surely be able to recall my statement regarding the dangers of overabundance of mana in the system? Repeat my words back to me.”

Ceria winced, but Pisces just cleared his throat, looking quite calm.

“Mana, sir, may over accumulate in any living being’s body as a result of a spell or influx of mana in a charged environment, but more often than not it is a result of imbibing a mana potion improperly. For a mage, casting any spell will usually resolve the issue, but for those without mana, time and rest are the only usual solutions. A competent mage may attempt to drain the excess magic from a person, but this action is not without risk. And in high concentration, excess mana may well lead to rupturing of blood vessels or parts of the body overloading or shutting down.”

Ceria and the other students in the room gaped as Pisces delivered a perfect summary of Rievan’s lesson from yesterday. The [Mage] stared hard at Pisces as the young man finished and sat down.

“Very...good.”

He said it grudgingly, and turned away from Pisces without another word.

“We will continue our lessons from yesterday! Clear your desks and begin forming your spells again. I want to see more attention to detail, Springwalker! And you—Elkrin, is it? Your control of your [Fire Orb] spell is abysmal! Focus your flames or don’t bother to cast the spell at all!”

The lesson ended without incident, which was to say Ceria ended up being scolded for her lackluster performance. But she was more concerned with Pisces. After it was over, she walked down the corridor with him.

“I can’t believe you memorized all of that!”

“I paid attention in class, and I have a good memory.”

Pisces scratched at his hair self-consciously as they entered the banquet hall. Ceria saw Calvaron and Beatrice at their usual spot and waved to them. She got her food and made her way over. She and Pisces had to pause as an older man carrying a tray nearly ran them over. He grunted and without a word of apology went to sit at an empty table.

“Stupid Human. I nearly dropped my plate!”

Ceria grouched as she sat down. She’d taken some pork chops roasted in a sauce that smelled like peanuts today. Pisces had a more balanced meal; he’d taken one of the pork chops and several sweet red fruits that tempted Ceria. He stared after the man, frowning.

“Isn’t that poor Elkrin? He seems upset.”

“Shouldn’t he be? You two were in Rievan’s class just now, weren’t you?”

Calvaron laughed and cleared part of their table so Pisces could put his food down. He and Beatrice were nearly finished with their meal—some kind of small, round pasta-like food drizzled with a thick sauce and accompanied by steamed vegetables.

“That’s right. Rievan tore a strip off of Elkrin for his spellcasting.”

Ceria nodded as she began to cut her meat apart. She still felt grouchy from having to deal with Rievan. She paused and narrowed her eyes at Calvaron.

“Wait a second. Isn’t that a secret I should be charging you for?”

He laughed and slapped at the lower, horse half of his body.

“Not *everything* is a secret, Ceria. Something as normal as that is just juicy gossip. But it looks like Elkrin’s not taking the dressing down well, is it?”

Ceria half-turned in her padded seat to look. Elkrin did have a murderous scowl on his face and no one was sitting with him. Calvaron shook his head as he *tsked*.

“Attitude problem. He may be a good adventurer, but you have to be willing to learn if you want to stay here. I bet he’ll be gone within the week.”

Pisces and Ceria exchanged a glance at this. They could understand not liking Rievan, but leaving because of that? Wistram was their dream.

Calvaron noticed the look.

“Only a few people actually quit, but they’re usually only adventurers. Some of them—even the good ones like the Gold-rank adventurers who come here to improve their craft—they don’t like being told the magic they practice is inefficient. So they leave.”

“Stupid. Arrogant.”

Beatrice put that in. The Dullahan was spoon-feeding her head on the table as usual, and she seemed content to let Calvaron do all the talking. Ceria had to agree with her, but she yawned as she opened her mouth. That made Pisces yawn too.

“Oho! You two look tired! Did you keep each other up at night, or is it just a coincidence?”

Calvaron dodged the rolled-up napkin Ceria hurled at him. He twisted his fingers and the ball of cloth flew back at her, forcing Ceria to duck or let it smack her in the head.

“Don’t throw things unless you can catch them when they come right back at you, Springwalker. Telekinesis and levitation spells come later in the year though, I’m afraid.”

“Great. I’ll be sure to heave my plate at you when your back is turned, then.”

Ceria growled as she picked her napkin up from the floor. Calvaron just laughed again. He was always ready to smile, which made Ceria wonder if all Centaurs were so good-natured. Beatrice on the other hand was as prone to smile as a rock.

“How were your other classes? Did you like learning about enchantments? I always found that class dull, myself.”

Ceria shrugged and Pisces smiled.

“Our teacher—Fedric—is fairly good at saying as little as he needs to.”

“Fedric? Oh, he would be. Dullahans are like that, aren’t they, Beatrice?”

Calvaron nudged Beatrice’s body, and her head on the table scowled at him.

“I say what I have to. I don’t run my mouth, Calvaron.”

“I’m surprised to see so many Dullahans in Wistram. No offense, but I’d barely heard of your people before coming here.”

Ceria looked at Beatrice with interest. Fedric, their teacher for their class on enchantments, was an old male Dullahan. She’d seen a number of them in the corridors as well.

Beatrice just shrugged her shoulders as she swiveled her head to talk to Ceria.

“Not too many. But all good spellcasters get sent here from Baleros. One continent means lots of Dullahan applicants.”

“True enough.”

Calvaron nodded. He pointed across the banquet hall, and Ceria saw a group of six Centaurs walking down the hall. They were far bigger than most students, and so they had to walk single-file to get in line.

“My people don’t usually go in for spellcasting, but like Beatrice said, the best come here and there are a lot of us on Baleros. That’s why you’ll see quite a few species that are rare in most places. Selphids, for instance.”

Ceria and Beatrice shuddered a bit at the mention of that race. Ceria had seen the deathly-white students walking the halls, dead bodies controlled by their parasitic owners. Calvaron shrugged stoically.

“They’re not so bad when you get used to them. I know they get a bad rap back home, but the ones here are all very polite.”

“Wistram truly does have more species than I’ve ever seen before.”

Pisces wiped at his mouth with a napkin. Calvaron grinned.

“We’re way more diverse than most cities, it’s true. Anyone who can become a mage or learn a magical class is welcome here—if they’ve got talent and coin. Of course, not all races are as gifted as others. That’s why you won’t see many Minotaurs, although I’ve heard they can make good mages. But most Minotaurs don’t like to use magic, so they’re not inclined to study here anyways.”

“And I bet some species aren’t as numerous or trusting of Wistram.”

Ceria said that thoughtfully as she chewed on some cow’s tongue she’d found under one of her pork chops. Calvaron grimaced and looked away as he replied—he hated to eat identifiable body parts, although he was surprisingly unconcerned about eating cows. Ceria had wondered if he would have been bothered by meat, but apparently Centaurs were far enough away from cows to eat them without guilt. She wondered how they felt about horses.

“You mean half-Elves, Ceria?”

She shrugged. She’d seen a few half-Elves roaming the halls, but they were far from common. She’d been tempted to talk with them, but it wasn’t as if she was back on Terandria and she had to stick with her own kind. Plus, she was a new student and she wasn’t sure if she’d make it past the exams.

“I know my people are naturally good at magic. But...I can’t say I’m surprised there aren’t many around. We’re not exactly welcome to strangers.”

“You and the Gnolls. You know, of all the species in the world, the only race who won’t set foot on Wistram are the Gnolls?”

“Really?”

Both Pisces and Ceria frowned at Calvaron. Ceria tried to think of a Gnoll, but only had a vague image of a furry dog-like person, similar to one of the Beastkin tribes from Baleros. She’d never seen one in person before; she heard they lived on Izril and seldom ventured as far as Terandria.

The Centaur nodded, frowning a bit as he explained.

“It’s a real pain too, apparently. A lot of Gnolls are famous [Merchants] and [Traders], you know. They’re pretty resilient and their tribes like to

move about exchanging goods. But none of them will do any kind of business with Wistram, even through middlemen. It's some kind of grudge, although I've never heard what it was about."

"Really? A Gnoll grudge? I hear they keep those for lifetimes."

"Too right. It's a shame too, because I'd bet their tribes would benefit from having a few of their number learn magic. But..."

Calvaron shrugged. Beatrice raised her head so she could get everyone's attention.

"A Gnoll did come here to study once, though. About a decade or two ago."

"A Gnoll? You're pulling my hoof, Beatrice."

"Nope. He came but dropped out before his first year was up."

"Why?"

The Centaur leaned towards Beatrice, but the Dullahan closed her lips in a slight smile.

"Secret. Pay me and I'll tell."

Everyone chortled at that. Calvaron was fairly rich in secrets Ceria had learned, and many students and mages came to him to exchange tidbits for goods and services. But Beatrice had her own collection of secrets, as any longtime mage in Wistram did.

"I don't know if it's worth a juicy secret. Would you consider a trade for something else? How about other goods and services rendered...?"

Calvaron wiggled his eyebrows at Beatrice and she smiled a bit wider.

"Not worth my time."

"Ah, you!"

They liked each other. It was quite obvious from the way they flirted. Calvaron did it openly, Beatrice with deadpan remarks that might be serious or a joke; you could never tell which.

"Looks like you'd better cough up a secret if you want to know, Calvaron. Me and Pisces don't have enough to cover the costs."

"I'll pass. You don't collect as many secrets as I do by spending them frivolously."

Calvaron waved a hand. Pisces looked intrigued and leaned forwards over the table.

"Just how many secrets *have* you obtained during your stay here, Calvaron?"

“That’s a secret in itself, my dear Pisces. But suffice it to say, I’ve got more than one person’s little tidbits locked away in my head.”

The Centaur tapped his head importantly. Pisces looked impressed as he nodded, but Ceria thought the Centaur was full of it. She raised her eyebrows.

“You mean, you’re a secret keeper? Ooh. *Fancy.*”

Pisces snorted. Across the table, Beatrice choked on her food. She had to place her head on the table while the rest of her body pounded on her chest. Ceria and Pisces nearly fell over themselves laughing as Beatrice’s face contorted and Calvaron had to reach over and slap her on the back a few times. When she was done, the Dullahan turned her head with her hands so she could glare at the two.

“Not that funny.”

“It was pretty funny. No one calls people like me secret keepers or—or shadow brokers or anything like that, Ceria. I’m just a broker, a middleman. Or middle-Centaur if you like. It doesn’t roll off the tongue as smoothly. I buy and sell.”

“And make a good profit, I’ll bet. You’re rich!”

“Wistram rich, my dear half-Elf. It’s not the same as being actually rich. If I left this small isle no one would know my name. Here I have a bit of power.”

“Which explains why you maintain your independent status. Any faction in the academy can treat with you without fear you’ll trade their secrets away. It’s a valuable position to be in.”

Pisces observed that as he glanced carefully at Calvaron. The Centaur’s eyes focused on Pisces and he gave the younger man a nod of respect.

“Sharp, aren’t you?”

“He hides it well. Tell us more about these factions, Calvaron. How did they pop up?”

“I don’t know. It’s a long story...”

Calvaron glanced at one of the windows that let bright sunlight into the room. Ceria knew this was just theatrics; the Centaur had very few classes she understood, and he liked to lounge around in the banquet hall with Beatrice.

“Come on, you’ve got time and we don’t have classes for the rest of the day. Give us new students a bit of history.”

The Centaur grinned as he popped another grape into his mouth.

“What, for free? This isn’t just gossip. Some of this stuff is important. I can’t just give it away! You know how it works. Secrets for secrets.”

Pisces and Ceria both groaned at the same time. Ceria was going to tell Calvaron she didn’t want to know that bad when Pisces raised a finger.

“Would a small one do?”

“For general history? I suppose.”

Calvaron’s eyes sharpened, and the Centaur leaned forwards. Ceria saw Beatrice’s hands move; the Dullahan’s head whispered something and Ceria felt magic around the four of them. Some other students looked around, but most seemed used to what was going on.

It was an exchange of secrets. Calvaron and Pisces spoke to each other, but Ceria only saw a blur around their mouths and heard nothing. The Centaur had pulled a small crystal out of a belt pouch; it glowed bright red as Pisces spoke. The Centaur nodded, and in the next moment the bubble of silence dissipated.

“Well, I’d say that qualifies. How did you find out?”

Pisces smiled enigmatically at the Centaur.

“Secrets for secrets. To learn my method, you’d have to pay quite a lot, my dear Calvaron.”

“I suppose I deserved that.”

Ceria was dying to know what Pisces had told Calvaron—it could be just pointless information, but how had Pisces found out? She knew she wouldn’t get an answer from the Centaur though, so she pointed at the gem that the Centaur was putting back into the pouch at his waist.

“Is your truth crystal broken? It glowed red when Pisces spoke.”

He shook his head, grinning.

“Nope. It’s a little trick. Most truth spells glow green or blue or white when someone tells the truth, right? I’ve enchanted mine to do the opposite. Sometimes you can throw someone off with it.”

Pisces nodded as if this was perfectly sensible, but Ceria just rolled her eyes again.

“Everything in Wistram seems like a trick or mind game.”

“That’s just because you’re new. You’ll get used to it quick enough. Now, I believe I owe you some history?”

All four students took the moment to refill their plates. Ceria took some cold cubes of ice and splashed them into a sweet drink of fruit, delighted at the luxury of it. She sipped at her drink as Calvaron began speaking.

“I suppose you know Wistram has been around for thousands of years. It was founded oh, way back, when a lot of nations were at war and mages wanted a place to learn and teach in peace. Well, Wistram may have gained and lost power over the years, but it’s always been independent. No nation controls us—we have an army of our own here and only a truly grand fleet could make it to our shores with weather spells raised against them.”

“Not to mention Wistram provides many services.”

Beatrice put that in. Calvaron nodded proudly.

“We do provide the best spells and mages. You can trust a Wistram-certified enchantment. And we can enchant weaponry and other artifacts as well. We do a booming trade with adventurers who want better gear or to have something analyzed—”

“Yes, yes. Wistram is great. That’s why we came here.”

Ceria cut in, impatient to get to the good part.

“What does this all have to do with factions? From what I’ve heard, they didn’t always exist.”

“No, Miss Busy half-Elf, they didn’t. And if you’d let me explain, you’d know that a few centuries ago, mages competed in Wistram quite fiercely. It was every mage for himself and they formed their own groups—but there was no faction. Instead, powerful mages attracted people to them. One of them was Archmage Zelkyr. Mind you, he wasn’t just an Archmage, but an *actual* [Archmage].”

“He obtained the class?”

Pisces’ eyes were shining, and Ceria scooted forwards on her seat. Calvaron nodded, looking just as excited by the idea.

“It’s a matter of history. The class *does* exist, and he and the other [Archmages] who ruled Wistram at the time all had them. But Archmage Zelkyr was the best. He was a Drake – famous, you know, for being able to damage one of the Walled Cities’ walls. But he was more famous for his ability to create Golems.”

“Cognita.”

Beatrice said it quietly. Calvaron nodded.

“Her and an entire army of Golems. They eventually made it so that Zelkyr was in undisputed control of Wistram. He alone explored the higher reaches of the citadel, searching for ancient magics left behind by the greatest mages in Wistram’s history.”

“Higher up? You mean, there’s places not yet explored in Wistram?”

Calvaron nodded as if it were obvious.

“Of course. How many mages do you think lived in Wistram? The greatest of them—legends who could cast countless magics—all settled the highest floors. If you go exploring higher and higher you’ll run across their creations, spells, and maybe their rooms. But imagine the amount of traps and dangerous spells up there! Just trying to break into a former mage’s room is deadly.”

“But Zelkyr had the monopoly on that, right?”

Ceria was beginning to understand what had happened, and why the upper floors were off limits now.

“He did indeed. Zelkyr ordered his Golems to guard the entrances to the upper levels and seal it off so only he could learn from the mages above. Of course, the other mages didn’t accept that and there was a huge battle. But in the end his surviving Truestone Construct—Cognita—imposed a new order on the surviving mages. They could live and study in Wistram, but the upper levels were for Zelkyr and the few he trusted alone.”

“Hence their current inaccessible state?”

“Exactly.”

Calvaron pointed a finger at Pisces as he stole a grape from Beatrice’s plate. She jabbed him with a gauntleted finger.

“*Gah!* Damn it Beatrice, it *hurts* when you do that!”

“Then don’t steal. Yes, Pisces, the upper levels are closed. The top three are only off limits for new mages, but after that—there is a door. Cognita and many golems guard it. It leads further up.”

“Okay, but why hasn’t anyone gotten Cognita to open it? Zelkyr is dead, right?”

“I’m getting to that! Hold on!”

Calvaron took a long drink, enjoying making Ceria and Pisces wait.

“One day, Cognita came down from the upper floors and announced that Archmage Zelkyr was dead. Ever since then, she and the other Golems have been maintaining Wistram. They still fulfill his orders by helping us, taking care of the academy, fighting off intruders and so forth, but his other order still stands. No one may venture above. So while Wistram is safe—”

“The higher magics are off-limits?”

Pisces looked dismayed at the thought. Calvaron waggled a finger at him.

“Just the ones that belonged to the greats. There’s plenty of mages here capable of casting Tier 5 spells, or even Tier 6. But higher than that...? You’ll have to get past Cognita first, and that’s pretty much impossible. If you challenge her, you’ll be fighting her and Zelkyr’s best creations.”

Beatrice’s armor shuddered a bit and she turned the corners of her mouth down.

“Golems. Scary.”

Ceria thought that was ironic coming from a Dullahan, but she had to admit that for all Beatrice was a disembodied head and a body covered in light metal armor, she was clearly alive. Cognita and the other Golems were not. There was an important distinction there.

“So Cognita’s not just a nice, friendly Golem?”

Calvaron snorted.

“She’s as nice as a Golem can be, which is sort of. But try to get past the door and...you’re dead. No one’s gotten past her since Zelkyr died.”

“And so far no one’s tried?”

“And so far no one’s *survived*.”

Beatrice said it quietly. Calvaron nodded soberly.

“Of course, countless mages challenged Cognita and the Golems in the past. Some did it by themselves, others attacked in groups or tried to catch the Golems off-guard. None succeeded. The Golems are powerful, and Cognita’s the strongest of them all. I’ve never seen her fight personally, mind, but there are other guardian Golems that Zelkyr made. Occasionally some group of mages decides to challenge them, but they’re always killed.”

Both Ceria and Pisces shuddered. Beatrice looked between them and shook her head with her hands.

“Don’t worry about it. So long as you never try to get past the door, you’ll be fine. And there are other places below the door that are still unexplored.”

“Like below. There’s plenty of passages unexplored there, although we do have a problem with the undead. There are a lot of bones stored in the catacombs and they sometimes reanimate people who get killed down there.”

“Lovely. And...wait, how does this have anything to do with *factions*?”

“I’m *getting* to that. You’re the most impatient half-Elf I know, Ceria.”

“I’m the only one who’ll put up with a Centaur like you, Calvaron.”

“Hah! True. Anyways, the factions in Wistram popped up because there’s no one mage who’s powerful enough to really control everyone like there used to be. Now our Archmages are just the greatest mages among us, not those with the actual class. And factions are just mages with similar ideals.”

“Like the Revivalists. My faction. You two should join if you pass the exam.”

Beatrice smiled at Pisces and Ceria. Calvaron rolled his eyes and tipped her head over.

“Stop that, Beatrice! Ignore her, you two. You don’t want to get wrapped up in factional politics before your exam. That could really hurt your chances to get in.”

“Why? Surely if we pledge to one faction, they could help us succeed?”

Pisces seemed curious. Beatrice took the moment to respond—she’d cast a spell that made all the hairs on Calvaron’s horse-half stand up, which the yelping Centaur was having to dispel.

“They might. But other factions don’t like giving one strength. So it’s a bad idea. Sorry.”

“Yeah.”

Calvaron gasped as he managed to remove Beatrice’s shocking hex. He glared at her, but she gave him a satisfied look and he decided not to escalate the situation.

“You won’t have to deal with them too much. Just know that some mages belong to a group with certain ideals. They differ in how they agree of course, but they stick together when it comes to voting or pushing their agendas. Illphres, for example. Remember her?”

Ceria ground her teeth together. She was still sore about not being taught any combat magic all this time she’d studied here.

“I do.”

“Well, she’s an Isolationist. Thinks we should only allow mages who are already strong to join and that we should be reaching for greater heights in magic. That’s why she didn’t want to teach you.”

“Can’t the other factions force her to teach?”

“They can...but Illphres is stubborn and it’s not worth the battle. They’ll use her not teaching to their advantage instead; the others will be able to say the Isolationists don’t contribute their fair share and be able to

vote against them. So Illphres is harming her own faction, but she's too influential for anyone to stand up to her."

"And meanwhile we suffer for it."

Ceria angrily stabbed her cold pork, but Calvaron just shrugged.

"It's bad luck I'm afraid. Sorry. But there are other factions in Wistram you should know about. Your good friend Rievan, for instance, belongs to the Libertarian group. They want us to start taking sides with different nations and throwing our influence around."

"Sounds like a bad idea."

"Don't let any of the Libertarians catch you saying that. A lot of them are from Terandria, and they take a deep interest in the politics from there."

"So factions are something else we'll have to worry about?"

Ceria didn't like the thought of that, but Calvaron just chuckled.

"Not for a while, and certainly not until you pass your exam. And if you get strong enough, you might be able to deal with factions on your own. The more important you are, the less your connections and factions matter. Then it's just about who you are as a [Mage]."

"But it sounds like unless I'm a powerful mage, I'll *need* to join a faction or be in danger."

Ceria pointed that out and Pisces nodded in agreement. Calvaron paused before shaking his head.

"Not necessarily. You see, the factions keep each other in check so that the independents like me can function. How can I explain it? Okay, let's say someone—a certain angry Elementalist teacher for instance—wanted to harass you. Because he doesn't like your ears."

"He *doesn't* like me because of my ears."

"Yes, but he's not actively trying to harm you or get in your way, is he? That's because if he did start attacking you, the Revivalists and the Preservationists would be all over him. They don't want him to alienate your people—or spread the rumor that Wistram is a speciesist institution."

"Preservationists? That's a long name, isn't it?"

"They chose it, not us. Anyways, Mister Angry Elementalist would have to have a lot of support from his faction to get at you. He'd also have to consider your friends, and how much the other factions would retaliate if he went at you. Mind you, you're hanging out with second and third-year students who aren't powerful. Beatrice is a [Runeshaper] and I'm just a generalist [Mage], so we don't have much clout."

“You study runes, Beatrice? You never said.”

Beatrice nodded. She tapped at her armor where Ceria now saw some carved symbols etched into the metal.

“Working on some personal enchantments. Rune magic is very popular among Dullahans. But not powerful in faction.”

“Right. But don’t worry—Rievan’s not going to try anything. It would be too much trouble if he did and you’re not worth it.”

“Thanks.”

“Hey, it’s just politics. Like how you got stuck with Rievan and Illphres anyways. That was due to a squabble with the factions.”

“Really? Would you mind explaining how that happened?”

Pisces was interested, although Ceria wasn’t. Calvaron shrugged.

“You really want to know?”

“I do.”

“I don’t.”

“Well, I’ll tell Pisces and you can just eat your dead pig, Ceria. Now, the current mages teaching are mostly mages who like doing it. Some mages earn their keep and just live here by teaching. It’s not going to make them influential, but it is necessary and so they keep doing it. But a year ago, Tshya, the old Drake who taught me and Beatrice, died.”

“Poor Tshya.”

“He had scale rot. Very nasty odor. He never cleaned himself right near the end.”

“Calvaron!”

“Well, he didn’t! Remember the smell? And he was old. But he was in charge of a lot of lessons, and so the council wanted another of the oldest and most inactive mages to take on the job. Unfortunately, that would have meant choosing Belfore—he’s a Preservationist, just like Yim, the other teacher who was taking on a lot of classes. But that would have meant that the Preservationists were essentially doing all the teaching, and they didn’t want to let that happen in case it became precedent. So they *insisted* that the teaching be taken up by mages from all factions, which led to, among others, Rievan getting tapped for the job.”

“He’s not that important. So he got the job.”

“I see. But what about Illphres? You said she was important?”

“Yes, well, the Centrists—they’re the ones who want us to make every mage in the world part of Wistram and declare ourselves a nation—they’re

always fighting with the Isolationists. And they really don't like Illphres, so they nominated her. And she's got a lot of enemies so they passed the vote and made her take the classes."

Beatrice smiled.

"Simple, right?"

"No!"

Ceria clutched at her head while Pisces nodded and kept asking more questions. Ceria went off to get dessert—a lovely bread with sugar baked into the crust and glazed with honey. Mages ate well at Wistram, but this was a treat. She returned to the table and suffered through more discussions of politics. Pisces looked hurt when she suggested they leave.

"You don't find this interesting? There's so much *depth* here!"

"Depth is for people who want it. I came here for magic, not politics."

Ceria groused. But she had one thought. She turned to Calvaron and Beatrice.

"What about Amerys? Does she belong to any faction?"

The two older students blinked at her. Calvaron slowly shook his head.

"Amerys? Some factions wouldn't have her simply for what she's done. Others might, but Amerys has never approached anyone. The mage of the King of Destruction's Seven stands alone."

"She has friends."

"More enemies than friends by a long shot. No, Amerys is alone, for all she's an Archmage. I'd walk clear of her if I were you. No one forces her to do anything. And she's unpredictable at best."

"Like when she went out to fight the Sea Serpent. That was a surprise."

"Not really. You know she likes battle, Beatrice."

"I thought she did it to gain favor with the Revivalists, or maybe the Centrists."

"Her? Hah! Never. Now, I can see one of the other Archmages doing that. Old Verdan Blackwood for instance could have taken down the Sea Serpent, but Amerys volunteered. Do you know what happened after that? Pisces, you're not going to believe this..."

Somehow, it was dinner time before the conversation ended. Ceria and Pisces loaded up their plates with more food and chatted with Calvaron and Beatrice for another hour until Ceria decided they really did need to get back to their rooms to study.

"I can't believe we talked for six hours!"

Ceria exclaimed out loud as she and Pisces headed back to their rooms. He only smiled, looking as happy as she'd ever seen him.

"It's wonderful isn't it? This place is such a haven of learning. I feel like I'm right at home when I have discussions like these."

"More like a place to get fat. I ate too much."

"Good food, magic, and interesting people to talk to. What's not to love?"

"Rievan. And Illphres. And Charles de Trevalier."

"Well, besides them."

Both students laughed as they went back to Pisces' room. There they pulled out the spellbook and stared at it. Ceria wanted to learn another combat spell, and Pisces was still staring at one spell he claimed to half-understand already. After a while, Pisces spoke.

"They're betting on us."

Ceria raised her head with a frown.

"Who are?"

"Beatrice and Calvaron. I heard they've put money that both of us will pass the exams."

"People bet on who'll pass? Wait, of course they do."

Ceria sighed. She felt annoyed that Calvaron and Beatrice were treating her getting into Wistram so trivially, but Pisces took the opposite view. He smiled at her.

"Don't be angry. If they didn't like us or care they wouldn't have made the bet. I think they're trying to help us. They give us tips and secrets for free all the time, don't they?"

"I guess. It's just—we're going to need more than a bit of help if we want to be sure we'll pass."

Ceria sighed, dispirited. Pisces raised his eyebrows and tapped the book in front of them.

"That's what this is for. Look here—I'm certain this spell is in fact [Flash Step]. I had to get to one of the encyclopedias to look it up, but the spell's description seems to match this spell exactly!"

Filled with sudden interest, Ceria peered at the spell. She nodded.

"You could be right!"

Then her face fell.

"But there's only three weeks left until the exams. Not enough time for either of us to learn it."

“I think I can do it. At the very least, I want to try.”

Ceria stared at Pisces. She knew he was smart. But this? [Flash Step] was a Tier 3 spell.

“You’re going to try?”

“Of course. And you can learn [Stone Fist] as well. If we work together, we’ll pass the exams.”

Pisces grinned at her. Ceria felt her heart pounding in her chest. Just heard it. She smiled at Pisces, and held up a fist for him to bump his cautiously against.

“Definitely.”

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Wistram Days (Pt.4)

Wistram was a world unto itself, with a different set of rules, a different kind of people. And yes, Ceria thought to herself as she cautiously opened her door, a different sense of time.

This early in the morning the hallway was empty. Seemingly empty. But Ceria knew better than to step out incautiously. She whispered a spell as she stared hard at the floor and ceiling.

“[Detect Magic].”

The world faded. Colors became less vivid in Ceria’s eyes, while others sprung out at her, as if they were the only real things in a blurred reality. And so when she looked again, Ceria could clearly see the hex that had been drawn on the flagstones in front of her door.

“Of course.”

It was a spell that would make the ground slippery like grease. Ceria moved to destroy the hex and then paused. She glanced suspiciously around the hex, and then peeked her head around the doorjamb. That’s when she saw the second, far less obvious spell about to go off.

She gritted her teeth. Ceria pushed mana into her hands and raised it. A jet of flame scorched the stone and disrupted the fragile matrix of the trap spell. The half-Elf grimly watched both spells disappear as she dared step outside at last.

“A shock spell? Dead gods. Those damn Human—”

She caught herself. She didn’t *know* it was a Human who’d cast the spell. But she was pretty sure it was.

“Charles de Trevalier.”

Ceria muttered his name as she stalked down the corridors towards the banquet hall. She was in no mood to wait for Pisces to get up—he usually woke up late unless they had class in the mornings, anyways. So Ceria contented herself with grabbing some fruit and a piece of cheese and eating alone at one of the tables.

Two weeks had passed since she and Pisces had stolen the spellbook, or rather, reclaimed it from the library with Cognita’s help. It wasn’t really stealing, actually. True, other students had found the book and probably

intended to retrieve it, but as Ceria and Pisces both pointed out to each other, they hadn't gotten to it in time.

Therefore the book was rightfully theirs, or rather, Pisces' property. Still, neither student had told a soul about what they'd done, even Calvaron or Beatrice. A secret like that would be worth a huge amount and Ceria didn't want to risk having a bunch of older students angry at them.

Especially not at this time. There was less than a week left until the exam that would decide everything for Ceria. In five short days, she'd be tested on her magical abilities and Skills, and demonstrate what spells she'd learned while studying here.

In truth, this was as much of a test of her abilities as a student as it was her prowess as a mage before she'd arrived at Wistram. Ceria had heard from Calvaron and Beatrice just what the tests measured.

"They'll look to see how powerful you are *and* whether you picked up on the lessons. If you're talented in either respect, you'll gain points. So a good mage could get accepted on their abilities or someone who's mastered every lesson could get in solely based on that, but it's best to be outstanding in both areas."

They'd be measured in many different areas, from their ability to control fundamental magic, to how they analyzed enchantments and held their cool in battle. There were several tests Ceria had practiced for, but it was the last one, a grueling obstacle course where the students would be allowed to use attack spells to get to the end quickly, that she was focused on.

After so long, Ceria knew how she ranked among the prospective students in Wistram. It was common knowledge; the entrance exams were the subject of quite a number of bets and power games, again according to Calvaron.

Your ranking was critically important, but Ceria knew it wasn't the only key to passing the exams. How much wealth you had—or your family had—and whether you were well liked by any influential mages could also be key.

Unfortunately, Ceria hadn't made any strong connections with anyone but Calvaron and Beatrice. She had no wealth besides the money she'd scraped together for the application fee. So all she could rely on was her talent.

And to be fair, Ceria wasn't bad at magic. She had a higher level than most new students, and she was also quicker than most at picking up each lesson. However, the key here was 'better than most'. Ceria wasn't at the top of her class; she was only gifted.

That wasn't reassuring. And to make it worse, Ceria knew someone who was consistently at the top of any class he took.

Pisces.

She hadn't realized it at first, but after nearly a month of hanging out with the young man and becoming friends, Ceria had realized he truly was a prodigy at magic.

Pisces could pick up a spell twice as fast as Ceria could. Worse, he had a finer control over his magic. *His* lightning didn't spark all over the place, and he could remember almost everything he was taught in class with his memory alone.

It made Ceria incredibly jealous at times. She knew Pisces couldn't help being gifted anymore than she could give up her race's affinity with magic that let them channel mana better than any other species. And yet, she couldn't help but feel that in a few days he might be the one to stay while she left.

Hence, her decision to wake up so early. Ceria glumly chewed down the last of her fruit and finished the cheese. She normally liked to eat meat—morning, noon and night and for a snack—but she couldn't have a full stomach for what she was about to do.

Leaving her dishes where they were—a Golem would come by and pick them up if some other students didn't levitate them to another table—Ceria headed towards the entrance of Wistram. In truth, she'd had little reason to leave the academy before now.

The half-Elf took a breath of the crisp morning air and then scowled as that crisp air turned out to be full of water. She spluttered as a wave crashing against the rocks of the isle sent a spray of water into her face.

"Nature."

She groused to herself as she stomped down the winding steps that led down to the large stone pier. The isle that was Wistram was really very small, in truth. Aside from the towering citadel that seemed to reach into the sky, there was only the docks and a separate bay where other ships could disgorge their cargo. Both were built out of stone and could hold dozens of vessels at a time, but Wistram had no grass or open areas to speak of.

All that was inside. Ceria had actually seen a large plaza filled with grass and trees in one part of Wistram, the top open to the sky. The magics that made up the citadel were such that the finite building that represented the outside couldn't hint at the full expanse of Wistram on the inside.

And yet today, Ceria left the steps and made her way down to a bunch of large boulders that protected Wistram from the direct impact of the tide. This early in the morning she saw only a few other mages about. Ceria found a secluded spot where she could stare out across the ocean and took a breath.

“Time to practice.”

The first thing she did was hurl a few orbs created with the [Light] spell. The shimmering spheres hovered in the air in front of Ceria, some relatively close, but others floated up to a hundred feet away. Ceria took a deep breath, and aimed carefully at the nearest one.

“[Stone Dart]!”

It was her favorite spell and the one she was most proficient at. The dagger of stone cut through the air with a whistling sound and pierced the center of the first ball of light. Ceria grinned triumphantly as it vanished.

She raised her hand and carefully aimed at the next orb. Ceria concentrated hard to make sure she was right on target; it wasn't just that she had to aim with her finger. The image of the floating orb was just as important in her mind; it could inform the angle and trajectory her spell took.

A second stone missile flew, and again the orb vanished soundlessly. The seagulls circling about the isle cawed raucously and the ocean waves blew up gouts of water while Ceria lined up her next shot.

She was practicing for the combat trial. Ceria knew most of the new students knew only a few combat spells and only Tier 1 spells at that. But she'd actually fought before! True, she'd only worked as a Bronze-rank adventurer to make ends meet now and then, but she was confident she could demonstrate her abilities in that section of the exam more than any other.

She just had to make sure her aim was spot-on. Thus, Ceria was practicing hitting the targets as they floated in the air. She'd done it all the time back in the forests around her home, only then she'd hunted animals and shot leaves out of trees. Here she had to make her own targets; she

wasn't about to kill the seagulls just to practice. Unless one of them pooped on her head, that was.

Ceria found aiming at the nearest orbs of light easy. She could hit them in rapid succession once she'd gotten her mental eye in. But past fifty feet her aim grew worse and worse. The wind blew her spells off course and she had to hit each ball of light in the center or she wouldn't destabilize the spell enough for it to vanish.

The final orb floated tantalizingly some one hundred and twenty feet away. Ceria cursed as she launched dart after dart at it, growing more tired with each shot. She could only fire about thirty or so before she had to rest and she was nearing her limit even with the short break she'd took.

But she was determined to hit it. Ceria waited for the wind to die down and then shot a dart across the ocean. She held her breath as she stared at the orb of light and then flung her arms out in success as it went out.

Only when she had finally shot down the last floating orb did Ceria realize she had an audience. She turned and nearly had a heart attack as she saw a cluster of mages, all far older than any of the students Ceria hung out with—watching her.

These were true mages, the ones who'd stopped being students and now either taught classes or studied magic on their own. Men and women in robes, Drakes, Lizardfolk—standing a ways away from the Drakes—a Dullahan and one of the Stitch People regarded Ceria silently. Ceria saw a bird-man standing next to two women she recognized.

Her heart stopped. There, standing with the mages was Illphres. And standing next to her, smiling slightly was none other than Amerys, one of the King's Seven.

The Calm Flower of the Battlefield. One of the King of Destruction's generals, who had conquered a continent and threatened the world. Ceria forgot she was a fellow mage for a second and froze in panic.

But these mages—why were they here? Had she broken a rule for some reason? Only, they didn't seem angry. They were just watching her. Some looked amused, others, considering.

“Um.”

Ceria could barely breathe. The mages regarded her for another silent moment, and then they moved off, as if they were done. Several leapt impossibly high into the air and floated down to rocks closer to the waves—others simply walked off in different directions around the isle.

Only one mage stayed. Illphres. She approached Ceria, moving slowly, face unreadable. She passed a hand over her lips and then Ceria saw a smile appear. It was slightly mocking.

“Sloppy aim.”

“What?”

“Your aim is bad. You took far too long to hit that last target.”

Illphres nodded slowly to the ocean. Ceria felt herself blush hotly as she realized all the mages had seen her struggle to hit her final target.

“I got it in the end!”

She was angry that they’d seen her, but angrier at Illphres for lecturing her. The mage passed a hand over her face and Ceria saw her smirking now.

“You can hit a stationary target, but you don’t compensate for the wind. If that was a Goblin archer he would have shot you full of arrows by now.”

That stung because it was true. Ceria replied sharply.

“So I suppose you’re telling me you can aim better?”

“Of course. Watch.”

Illphres pointed, and Ceria looked up. She saw only the sky, and a flock of seagulls looking for scraps or perhaps a tasty mollusk washed up by the tides. The ice mage gestured, and one of the passing seagulls suddenly *squawked* in terror and plummeted towards the ocean. Ice had encased both of its wings.

Ceria bit her lip. That was a masterful shot; she’d barely seen the streak of light that had shot from Illphres’ hand to hit the bird. But killing an animal just to prove a point seemed wrong to her.

But the seagull never hit the water. A few feet before it would have smacked into the surf pounding the rocks around Wistram it suddenly flapped its wings and flew back upwards, still making sounds of distress. Ceria saw the ice on its wings flaking off, melting with rapid speed.

The gull flew off, and Illphres turned back to Ceria. She passed a hand over her face and looked expressionlessly at Ceria again.

“Everything is a moving target. You’ll never improve by aiming at stationary points.”

It was all true, but Ceria just couldn’t accept the lecture. She pointed at Illphres angrily.

“Teach me, then! Show me how to cast better spells!”

“Melt my ice first.”

Illphres looked at Ceria, and the half-Elf didn't know what to say in reply. Illphres walked off, leaving Ceria alone to fume.

Ceria didn't stay long after her encounter with the mages. She saw them standing on the rocks, doing something close to what she'd done. The only difference was the scale. Instead of sending out orbs of light, some created actual illusions of monsters or incoming spells which they in turn warded against or shot down with their own magic.

She saw Illphres shooting countless discs of frozen ice up into the air at extreme speed and then bolts of lightning catching each one and blasting it to bits. Amerys did that for about ten minutes before she switched and started conjuring birds made of electricity which Illphres shot down in turn.

So. Other mages did what she did? Ceria walked back to Wistram, thoroughly humiliated and not a little bit angry. It was still early and she debated going back to the banquet hall for a second breakfast and to meet up with Pisces before class today. But she paused when she saw him in the hallway.

He wasn't alone. Pisces was talking with another Human—a young man Ceria recognized with a sinking feeling in her stomach. He had a pointy nose and far too gangly legs in her opinion, but he was attired in rich, colorful clothing like a [Lord]. Which he was, she supposed. It wasn't Charles himself, but one of his good friends.

Timor du Havrington.

He looked condescending as ever, but what was he doing here talking to *Pisces* of all people? Ceria stared down the busy corridor full of students hurrying about. He and Pisces were talking while they stood next to an intersection. About what?

About her?

She didn't want Pisces to see her. Ceria pressed her back against a wall and then realized that was stupid. Instead, she mingled with a group of students going one way, watching Pisces out of the corner of her eye as she walked.

“...happen to agree with you on that point, Havrington. However...”

That was all she heard as she passed by. Ceria desperately wanted to turn and look back, but she was afraid of being spotted. And afraid,

perhaps, of what she might hear. She slowly made her way back to her room and only saw Pisces again during lunch.

“Well, well. If it isn’t my favorite half-Elf! Where’ve you been Ceria? We missed you at breakfast! Wait—don’t tell me. I already know.”

Calvaron’s cheerful greeting made Ceria want to pull his tail. She scowled at him and ducked as a flash of magic flew overhead. He and Beatrice didn’t seem to notice, but then, they’d erected a shield spell around their table.

“Hi Calvaron. Hi, Beatrice. What in the name of tree fungus is going on?”

She pointed across the hall at the circle of students watching two mages exchange blasts of magic, but Calvaron began laughing instead.

“What in the name of—did you hear that Beatrice? Did you hear what she said? Do all half-Elves swear by plants?”

“I did. Be polite.”

Beatrice slapped Calvaron on the shoulder and pointed towards the two fighting mages.

“It’s a duel. Seric and Zepheral are quarrelling over a wand one of them found in an unexplored room. The winner gets to keep it.”

Calvaron nodded.

“Want to place a bet? The smart money’s on Seric, but Zepheral could pull it off. I’ve got three-to-one odds on Seric.”

Pisces, eying the battle warily, ducked as a stray arrow of light splashed across the top of their shield.

“I’m ah, more worried about our safety. Do such duels occur often?”

“Worried? Hey, this shield spell won’t break from a stray shot! And yes, duels are fairly common. I’m surprised you haven’t seen any before, but then, the Council likes to ease you new students into life here. Can’t have fights breaking out on the first day.”

“And students duel for money, pride, what?”

“Anything and everything, Ceria! It’s like secrets; just another way for a mage to get ahead if they so choose. And you don’t have to fight with spells—there are spoken debates too.”

“Really?”

Pisces' eyes lit up at that. Calvaron wagged a finger.

"Ah, ah. They're usually decided by collective vote, so don't go thinking the student who knows the most words wins, Pisces. It's actually quite tricky, since you can't rely on personal magnetism to win the debate. Those who vote have to answer under truth spell who made the more convincing argument."

"All the more reason for me to attempt this. You say you can win money with this?"

Pisces grinned at Ceria, who had to force herself to smile back. Calvaron nodded, wincing good-naturedly as a cry went up from the crowd watching the duel.

"Students duel with magic and words in the halls of Wistram. Well, I say students, but all the [Mages] here do it. The older ones just do it with a lot more pomp and ceremony. Ooh! Looks like Seric's going to win this one. Did you see that, Beatrice? [Air Volt]. Right to the chest! Zepheral's not walking away from that one."

"Looks like I win my bet. Good."

Pisces and Ceria watched as the crowd began to disperse. Apparently Seric had won, and some students were helping to magically carry Zepheral—the unconscious Drake—away.

"Never a quiet moment in Wistram, huh?"

"You know it. But Ceria, I hear you had an interesting encounter this morning."

Pisces turned, eyebrows raised and Ceria scowled at the Centaur.

"Dead gods, Calvaron! Do you keep your ear pinned to the ground or something?"

"Only when it involves my friends. And quite a few people saw you practicing outside. And how you ran into all the other mages too."

Ceria covered her face as Pisces demanded and received an explanation.

"Why were they out there? I thought I'd be alone that early in the morning."

Beatrice blinked slowly at Ceria as she scratched an itch on the back of her head.

"Don't you know? All the mages inclined towards combat get up early to train. They probably wondered whether you wanted to join them."

"Oh bark mold."

Ceria put her head in her hands and groaned as Pisces and Calvaron laughed.

“Shut up! I didn’t know, okay?”

“Don’t fret, Springwalker. Look at it this way; attracting their attention can’t hurt you, especially if they think you might be an asset to the academy.”

“It can if they saw how badly I did! I was trying to get back my aim in *secret!*”

“Well, you should have practiced elsewhere. The rocks around the academy are a favorite spot for all mages to practice. Less bodies to hit if their aim’s off, you see.”

“I didn’t know you were practicing. Was it for the exam?”

Pisces looked at Ceria with a frown. She nodded, not meeting his eyes.

“Ceria’s got the right idea, Pisces. She’s rated high for passing the combat portion ahead of most of the students. You should just try and get top marks in other areas. Mind you, you might have a shot at doing well in the combat portion too, given that no one’s taken classes in combat magic so far.”

“Thanks to Illphres.”

“I hate her so much.”

Ceria mumbled to herself as she stuffed her mouth full of cottage cheese. Calvaron shrugged.

“It’s not good for anyone, but hey, after the exams I’m sure the Council will find someone else to teach you lot. They can’t have you not being taught for an entire year.”

“Too late if we fail.”

“You’re so pessimistic! But hey, speaking of Illphres, did you know that Charles de Trevalier got into her classroom?”

“No.”

Pisces and Ceria both stared at Calvaron in shock. He nodded.

“Apparently, your good friend Charles was seen in the classroom. He caused a big commotion, calling for Illphres to come and teach him.”

“So she taught him, then? How’d he manage to get past the ice?”

“That’s the thing.”

Calvaron’s eyes twinkled in amusement.

“He got in, but apparently he got someone else to melt the ice for him. Anyways, it was obvious he hadn’t done it himself, so Illphres said it didn’t

count. I heard she and Rievan were arguing about it and she nearly froze his face off. He's probably the one who did it, although it must have been a struggle."

"Rievan and Charles are working together?"

Ceria exchanged a horrified glance with Pisces. She'd noticed Rievan didn't pick on Charles nearly as much for his failures, but she hadn't expected the two people who hated her most to join forces. Calvaron nodded seriously.

"Oh yes, Charles is heavily in Rievan's camp now. He's part of the Libertarian faction for sure. They'll love having someone with his family's deep pockets and influence, that's certain. And if they throw a bit of help back towards his family when they're having their own political battles, well, everyone wins."

"Great. Just great."

Ceria put her head down on the table. Pisces patted her gingerly on the back while Calvaron and Beatrice discussed what they'd do with their winnings.

"I think this is a great time to break out that drink I just bought. Beatrice, can you get some more quiches? Or maybe some of those eggrolls—or just cold cuts of meat? I'm told this goes well with spicy food, but I hate spices."

"On it."

The Dullahan left the table as Ceria raised her head in time to see Calvaron producing two glasses and a bottle and placing them on the table. He had a very limited bag of holding that let him carry objects around.

"What's this? Are you drinking at lunch?"

"Just a bit, just a bit. I made a good bundle betting on that duel. And this is a treat. Here—Pisces will you hold this bottle? I need to get this out..."

"What's that? Salt?"

Ceria watched disbelievingly as Calvaron took out a small pouch of salt and began to add it to the rims of the glasses. He lined one and then poured some of the pale lime-colored liquid into the glass.

"There we are. Mm. This smells good. This, my dear Ceria, is called a Sand Tumbler—it's an alcohol made with limes and lemons, I think. Don't ask me why it's called that. It's a tasty drink—an alcohol I just bought from a ship captain who had a cargo full of drinks."

"But salt?"

“It’s part of how you drink it. Again, don’t ask me why. But it—ooh, it does taste good! Here, Beatrice, you have to have one of these!”

Calvaron sipped from his glass with appreciation and delight. Beatrice, returned with a platter of food, reached for her own glass to prepare it like he had. Calvaron drank his, but objected when he saw Beatrice sprinkling the salt.

“Aw, Beatrice! Don’t put salt *in* the glass! A Sand Tumbler is supposed to have it on the rim. It adds to the taste!”

“I like salt. What about on the ice?”

“No, no! It’ll melt the ice and—look, let me do it, alright?”

Huffily, he showed Beatrice how to prepare the glass properly. When she was sipping it with apparent appreciation he turned back to Ceria and Pisces.

“I like to treat myself to the latest delicacy when I can afford it. Did you know this comes from Chandrar? It’s very refreshing—do either of you want to try one?”

Pisces declined. Ceria was sorely tempted, but she knew she had better spend all her time studying, not drinking.

“We’ve got to cram as much as we can right now, Calvaron. I’d love to stay, but unless you want to show us how to decipher complex enchantments—”

He groaned and Beatrice rolled her eyes.

“Dead gods, I’d rather let Illphres use me as a target than study that again. You two go study. Good luck!”

The two students left Calvaron and Beatrice to share their drink with a few students who’d drifted over, lured by the call of alcohol and snacks. Pisces was excited about the duel and Ceria was quiet, conflicted by her doubts.

“I do believe I might actually participate in a duel. Not a physical one—I’d rather not get hurt—but a verbal duel sounds promising! I might make some spending coin off of it. What do you think, do I have a chance?”

“If your opponent gets half as confused as I do, you’ll win for certain.”

Ceria smiled weakly at Pisces as they walked into his room. It had become their place to study, mainly because it was so convenient. And it had a balcony. He eagerly began spreading his notes over his bed and table as Ceria took a chair.

“What shall we focus on today? I thought we might work on our spell composition. I know that Rievan’s focused on it a lot already, but I think there’s room to improve.”

“Um, Pisces.”

He looked up as Ceria spoke quietly. Her heart was pounding, but she had to know.

“What is it?”

“Earlier this morning, I saw you talking with Timor. What was that about?”

She watched his face anxiously. Pisces wasn’t a good liar, Ceria knew. Or she thought she knew. He paused, and scratched at his hair as if trying to remember.

“Him? Oh that—nothing of consequence. I was just on my way to breakfast and he stopped me—”

“Pisces, please. I have to know.”

He paused, and then turned to look Ceria in the eye. Pisces sighed, and took a seat on his bed.

“Timor did, in fact approach me this morning to extend an invitation to me. To join him and Charles in their...faction. The Libertarians. They offered me quite a few incentives.”

Ceria felt a hand squeezing at her heart. It wasn’t what she’d feared, but it still made her worried.

“And? What did you say?”

“I refused him outright, of course!”

Pisces looked indignant and hurt that Ceria had to ask. He stood up, smoothing his robes.

“I told him no, but he kept pestering me. He wanted me to abandon my friendship with you so I could add my abilities to Charles and support him. I’ve apparently got good odds to pass the exam and the Libertarians want every new student they can get.”

“Why’d you say no? They can offer you a lot more than you’d get by being independent.”

“Hardly. You know what Calvaron said about factions.”

“Yeah, but...”

Ceria trailed off miserably. She didn’t want to suspect her friend, but she did. Pisces looked at her, and his tone softened.

“Ceria, I turned him down. I would never join with him. You are my... friend.”

He said the word cautiously. Ceria blinked up at him and Pisces colored. He turned and spoke rapidly.

“Besides, Timor’s offer was quite disingenuous, I felt. I am completely disinclined to subsume myself into a close-minded group that bows to the most influential member without discourse or free thought. Your company—and that of the other myriad members of each species—is far more pleasant for me.”

That was what he said, but his real meaning was far easier to understand. Ceria surprised herself by standing up and giving Pisces a quick hug.

“You’re a good friend Pisces, but you talk too much.”

He grinned at her, embarrassed, but pleased.

“So I’ve been told. Were you really that worried?”

“Not really—well, okay, a bit. Charles has it out for me.”

“I know he doesn’t like you, but do you really think he would try to get to you through me?”

Pisces frowned, but Ceria nodded with conviction.

“Positive. He doesn’t do anything openly, but you heard Calvaron. Charles is allied with Rievan and I think he’s been doing other stuff in secret. I’ve been finding trap spells and hexes around my room every few days when I wake up. I think he and his friends are planting them there each night.”

“I didn’t know about this! Why didn’t you tell me?”

Pisces looked outraged. He eyed Ceria and then turned red.

“You thought *I* was the one doing it?”

“I was wrong, okay? Look, Pisces. I know you’re a good friend. I do. But you’re Human and there’s a history between my people and yours.”

“So I’ve been given to understand, but this much? Charles didn’t like you on sight, but why? Is there really that much animosity?”

Ceria nodded tiredly. She wasn’t surprised Pisces didn’t know; if he’d grown up away from half-Elves or in a different nation he wouldn’t have the same perspective.

“I’m a half-Elf. He’s a Human noble. At one time my people ruled over most of Terandria and enslaved Humans. It’s a longstanding grudge and it’s not as if Humans and half-Elves have gotten along splendidly since then.

I'll just bet Charles is from one of the Human families my people used to enslave."

"Ah."

"Yeah."

"Or it could just be he hates half-Elves. Some Humans just hate other species. Stitch-people are widely accepted although some people get freaked out by them, but half-Elves are much more disliked. Lots of Humans hate us just for being, well, half Elf."

"I don't."

"Yeah, but you're a bit strange."

"Thank you."

Pisces grinned. Ceria smiled at him and felt better. He cleared his throat, looking at his scattered notes.

"Not to change the topic, but regardless of whether Charles is planning something, if we don't study we'll fail the exams anyways. Should we get to work?"

"Absolutely. Come on, let's practice. Show me how you get your lightning to go straight, will you?"

That night, Ceria slept more soundly than she had for a few days. But she was woken up just past midnight by a loud scream just outside her door. She sat up, heart pounding as she heard panicked voices outside.

"Aah!"

"What *are* they?"

Ceria heard shouting as she ran to wrench her door open. When she raced out into the corridor, hands ablaze with fire, ready to throw it at whoever was outside, she saw retreating shapes running down the corridor. They were being followed by a stream of...

"Ceria?"

Pisces yanked open his door, looking bleary-eyed and confused. He stared around, but now the corridor was deserted. A few other students were opening their doors as well, wondering what was going on.

"I think they were trying to put a trap on my door again. But something chased them off."

"How strange."

Pisces looked innocent. Too innocent. Ceria squinted at him suspiciously.

“You did something, didn’t you? What chased them off?”

“Mice, I believe. I ah, cast a spell to attract a few of them.”

Pisces grinned at Ceria and closed the door. She stared at it and smiled before going to sleep. If the next day Calvaron pointed out a few Human students with small bites all over their arms and legs, neither Pisces nor Ceria commented on it. Some secrets were just that: secret.

In the last few panicked days of studying, one last important thing happened as Ceria and Pisces were studying. Both mages poured over the spellbook they’d taken from the library each night before they went to sleep. Ceria had given up on learning [Stone Fist] in time—she thought with a week or two she might do it, but not when she had to devote her time to memorizing all her lessons.

But Pisces doggedly worked at decoding the spell he’d focused on. And as Ceria was sitting with her back to a wall in his room, trying to create the perfect [Stone Dart] to use as a model for her spells, he suddenly exclaimed and shot to his feet.

“I’ve figured it out!”

She looked up. Pisces was waving his arms about. He took a step—and suddenly blurred, appearing several feet forwards in an instant. She gaped. He turned to her triumphantly ecstatic.

“Look, look! Ceria, look! I can do the spell!”

He took another step and vanished. Ceria heard a yelp and saw him reappear and knock over the desk. Pisces jumped about and cradled his shin. She was dumbstruck.

“What? But how?”

“[Flash Step]! I told you I could learn it! It’s so useful! See—look at this!”

He took another step and appeared right in front of Ceria. She recoiled, but Pisces just grabbed her hands.

“I did it, Ceria! It’s so wonderful.”

He stepped away from her, disappearing and reappearing again. Ceria watched, open-mouthed. Pisces took a deep breath.

“It works. And I can use it. If I...”

He broke off, and began to mumble to himself. Ceria just stared at him. He’d really done it. And so quickly! It had been what, less than three weeks? She couldn’t imagine any other new student learning a Tier 3 spell so quickly.

But he’d done it. And now Pisces did something that made Ceria go speechless. He took another step and disappeared. Reappeared. He wasn’t teleporting, but rather moving so quickly around the room that he generated his own gusts of wind. But Pisces wasn’t doing it randomly.

He moved about the room, slower now. Ceria watched, mouth slightly open as she saw Pisces’ energetic leaping about turn into something else.

Was it a dance? Ceria had seen a waltz before, and what Pisces did now looked similar. His feet moved slowly, but with each step he flicked a few feet away. And yet, not once did he crash into a wall. Slowly, Pisces circled the room, stepping, turning, one arm on his hip, the other held outwards.

Turn, step, pivot, step. Pisces snatched up his rapier and then it was in his hands. He circled the small room, vanishing from sight and reappearing, facing off against some imaginary opponent. Just...circling.

If he hadn’t been using [Flash Step], Pisces would have just been moving about in a complicated dance of steps with rapier in hand, to better maneuver around his opponent. But with the spell he was suddenly impossible to predict. He moved about Ceria and she was sure that if she had a sword she’d be hard pressed to strike at him.

Still, that wasn’t what kept her eyes on Pisces. It was that he never hit anything. His room was large, yes, but even so, one careless step or moving a bit too far with the [Flash Step] spell would send him face-first into one of the stone walls. Yet Pisces never hit anything. He moved around gracefully, exerting perfect control over a spell he’d learned just moments ago.

Pisces walked for a long time, rapier held at the ready, doing a dance that made it appear like there were ten versions of him in the room at once, all flicking in and out of sight. Ceria watched silently, spellbook in hand. She stared at the young man, eyes closed, face upturned. She wondered who he was, who he had been before he had come here.

He was a genius. Pure and simple. And she envied him and delighted in the fact that he was her friend. A Human. A Human she could call friend.

She wanted to keep studying with him. She wanted to pass the exam. But when Ceria looked at Pisces, dancing about with flawless perfection,

she knew she'd never be able to copy what he did. So Ceria bent down over her spellbook and got back to studying. She had to pass.

She had to.

The day of the exam, all the prospective students gathered in front of the double doors where their exam would take place. Ceria supposed finding the spot was an exam in itself; any student who couldn't navigate Wistram's halls by now deserved to fail.

All of the students stood talking or practicing spells by themselves or in small groups. Ceria was with Pisces. Neither student had had the stomach to eat much this morning. They'd already been wished well by Calvaron, Beatrice, and a few other students who were rooting for them.

Now Ceria stared at the two marble doors, wondering why anyone would bother making doors out of marble so she didn't worry about how she was going to perform. There could be no mistakes, she knew. If she failed, or if she took more than one try to do something, it would be noted by the mages who'd gathered to watch.

There weren't a dedicated group of examiners for the test. Some mages like the teachers had to attend, but all the mages had a voice in choosing who would pass and who would fail. That made Ceria worried.

Very worried, especially when she saw Rievan talking with Charles and a group of his friends off to one side. The young man looked too relaxed, and so did Timor and a few other of his friends.

"I bet they'll pass one way or another. If Rievan can't get them through, Charles and Timor can just pay their way in."

Pisces muttered that to Ceria. She nodded, glaring at Charles. He looked over and saw her. Before Ceria could debate whether to look away he was approaching.

"Don't fight, Ceria."

"I won't."

She murmured it and then looked up to glare at Charles.

"Something you want, Charles?"

"That's Charles de Trevalier to you, half-Elf. And this hallway is free for anyone to use, as is Wistram. Not that your people would know what being free meant."

Timor sniggered behind Charles. Ceria saw some heads turn, but she was in no mood to spar with Charles. She shot back at the young man.

“Go boil yourself. You smell like rotted fish.”

Charles’ nose turned white with outrage, but before he could retort, Ceria walked away from him. Pisces followed, grinning happily.

“I do believe that was the most civil conversation you’ve had with him.”

“If I fail the exam, it’ll be the last. That would be the one silver lining.”

“It won’t come to that. We’ve studied.”

He squeezed her arm, and Ceria smiled at him. And then, before both students were ready, the doors opened. A mage stepped out, making the students go instantly quiet as if he’d cast a [Silence] spell.

“Come in groups of eight! Order has no meaning.”

The exams were beginning. Caught off-guard, some students fearfully retreated, not wanting to be the first ones in. Others decided that boldness might earn them points and headed in. Ceria and Pisces held back until the third group, and then took the exam.

“A large number of applicants this year.”

The mages who’d gathered to watch the new students take the tests were a diverse group, both in race and faction. Of course, every group in Wistram wanted to evaluate promising students, but some had come to support their candidate, or just to mingle and talk amongst themselves.

Some were here against their will, too. Illphres stood with a group of influential mages, both in power and status, scowling as she stared at the students casting magic under the instruction of a mage performing the test. A few feet away from her, Rievan hovered, not quite in the group which consisted of mages from every major faction, but unwilling to mingle with other mages. He kept interjecting comments or agreeing with a comment from one of the mages which several found quite annoying.

“Too many students is what I think. This is taking too long.”

Illphres folded her arms. The scowl on her face didn’t change until she passed a hand over her face and it returned to its expressionless stare. The mage standing next to Illphres, a tall Dullahan with his head held up to stare at the students, chuckled. He was unusually talkative and good-natured for a

Dullahan, which meant he was about normal when compared to how much Humans acted out.

“You’d say that if we had one applicant, Illphres. But some of these candidates are genuinely talented. Look at those two. The half-Elf and the young Human on the left side. See?”

“I see. So what?”

A pale Selphid, hair dyed dark blue, stroked his beard thoughtfully as he studied Pisces and Ceria showing off their control of magic with the other students.

“A half-Elf? She’s not bad and they do have more talent than most. But the Human next to her—”

“Gifted.”

One of the Lizardfolk said that. She was a tall, sinuous woman with a head that resembled a cobra’s. Her arms and legs were longer than a Drake’s and she was distinctly reptilian, whereas the Drakes more closely resembled Humans and their draconic ancestors. She nodded at Pisces approvingly as he demonstrated his perfect control over the [Electric Jolt] spell.

“Ooh yes. I like him. He’s very good. We should accept him.”

Rievan raised his voice hurriedly as the others agreed.

“We haven’t finished the tests, Quexia. I think there’s still more considerations to be made. I told you, we’ve already seen some good candidates. Charles de Trevalier for instance is quite talented for being so new to the craft—”

“Shut up, Rievan. No one’s interested in a lordling with money. He can buy his way in if he wants, but he’s as talented as my left toe. Less.”

Illphres interrupted without looking at the mage. Rievan flushed angrily, but dared not reply. He glared instead at Pisces and Ceria, fervently wishing bad luck on them.

Ceria felt like she was making a mistake every time she cast a spell. She was so nervous her hands shook. It didn’t help matters that she’d spotted Rievan among the watching mages, and he seemed like he was trying to cast a spell on her with his eyes alone. Ceria was pretty sure that was impossible, but it added to the pressure she felt.

She felt herself getting tired and worried—and a bit lightheaded because she'd forgotten to eat enough! And always, she could feel Rievan's gaze on her. It made Ceria make simple, stupid mistakes a few times and she berated herself for slipping up.

The exams were exhaustive. Even with eight or more students being tested at a time, they took a while. Ceria had to do everything from repeat lessons on magical theory to demonstrate spells they'd learned, or pick out dangerous artifacts from a lineup presented to her. Some of the tests were easy, just to make sure she knew what she was doing, but others were fiendishly hard, so that the best students could distinguish themselves.

Ceria did passably well at everything. She was proud of herself for picking out an artifact that would have caused horrible itching out of a lineup when everyone but Pisces had missed it, and mortified when her [Stone Dart] spell was found to have an imperfection in its composition. But she thought she hadn't done anything *too* badly wrong, so Ceria kept going.

Soon, she and the other students were done with all but one of the tests and she had to lean exhaustedly against a wall as Pisces nervously paced back and forth around her. There was only one test left, and Ceria tried to gather all of her wits about her for it.

"Alright, the combat test is next. You, students. Twenty of you come with me. The rest of you will have to wait."

Ceria's stomach twisted into a knot as she heard those words. This was it. Time to prove she could fight as well as cast magic. She didn't join the second group, but told Pisces she was going in the next one.

"I'll go with you. Just don't hit me with a spell, please."

"You'll just dodge it if I do. Are you going to [Flash Step] your way to the end? And why'd you bring your rapier? You won't need it!"

He grinned at her nervously, hands shaking. He had buckled the rapier to a belt over his robes which made him look slightly ridiculous, but Ceria hadn't told him that.

"I might. I have no idea what's going to be on the test. Did you know, last year Calvaron said the examinees had to fight a Troll?"

"They did not! Who'd be stupid enough to pit new mages against a Troll? They'd be dead in a heartbeat!"

"I'm just saying—"

The doors opened. Ceria jumped, and walked towards the mage before he announced they were ready for the next group. She heard a groan as Pisces joined her.

“What, *what?*”

“Look to your right. See who’s joining us?”

Ceria turned and saw Charles and Timor and two of their friends standing with the mages. Her heart sank as they smirked at her.

“What are they doing?”

“I don’t know. They can’t interfere during the exam. Not with all the mages watching—”

“I guess.”

Ceria wasn’t so sure, but there was no time to do anything. The mage took them down a corridor, and then Ceria entered into a strange corridor.

The walls, the ceiling, the floor seemed...vaguely transparent. Ceria gasped as she saw the stones were actually ghostly replicas of the real thing. And yet, the mage assured them the corridor was solid.

“Mages will be watching from the outside. Ignore them. Your only job is to prove you can navigate your way down the corridor and pass the other obstacles with your own magic. If you fail, just say so and you will be removed. Your speed, ability to handle each obstacle, and resourcefulness will all be taken into consideration. You will begin when I say so.”

Ceria eyed the empty stone corridor with trepidation. She had no idea what was ahead of her, but she was bursting with nervous energy. Beside her, she felt Pisces tensing.

“*Now!*”

At the mage’s words the students started. Ceria took two steps forward and *ducked* as a fireball came hurtling down the corridor towards the group of students. Half of them screamed, one fainted, and Pisces vanished.

“Ceria!”

Standing together watching the students make their way through the first part of the combat test, the mages chortled as the fake [Fireball] spell burst harmlessly among the group, showering them with fire.

“I never stop enjoying that.”

“One of the students has fainted? Well, I think he’s out.”

“Did you see that, though? The half-Elf dodged most of the blast, but that young man avoided it completely!”

“[Flash Step]. At his age? Impressive.”

“Now, how will they do with the traps? Oh? Looks like that half-Elf is quite daring. Isn’t she the one I saw practicing in the morning?”

Illphres watched Ceria navigating the traps ahead of the others. She was doing well, avoiding or disarming the ones in front of her.

“She’s nothing special.”

“Well, she’s doing well enough. Oh, look. That Trealier boy’s set off three traps. Hah!”

Rievan ground his teeth as he watched the students move through the hallways of traps. But he comforted himself, knowing what came next.

“Monsters!”

Someone screamed that, which made Ceria want to kick them. She dove out of the way as a shimmering bird that seemed to be made of light dove at her. Of course it was a monster! If you had the time to shout it, you might as well cast a spell!

“[Stone Dart]!”

She shot the bird through the head and it dissipated into fragments of light. All around her, students were fighting a swarm of magical creatures, the next part of the gauntlet that was their combat test. Ceria had gotten into the room first, but she’d been hard-pressed to progress. Some of the illusions were the circling birds who dove at you from overhead, but there was a huge Troll guarding the exit and she was wary of getting close.

“A damn *Troll*? Someone’s got a sick sense of humor!”

She growled as she shot down a huge wolf that was running at her, mouth open. All the illusions seemed so *real*! She’d already been hit twice, but instead of being injured, the apparitions had left bright, shining marks where they’d struck her.

Ceria was determined not to get hit again. She saw some students scream as a flock of the shimmering birds dove at them. Pisces was blinking around the room, dodging desperately and she saw most of the other students were huddled near the entrance of the trap corridor, throwing spells desperately.

This was her chance. Ceria called all the mana she could into her fingers and aimed at the swarm.

“[Stone Dart]!”

This time not one dart flew, but a score of them. Ceria fired the spell repeatedly, shooting jagged shards of rocks into the swarm, trying to hit as many birds as possible.

A score of the shimmering birds fell, the light-flesh of their bodies shattering and fading as they struck the floor. Ceria grinned as she ran forwards at the head of the group. There were still monsters left, but she had a clear shot to the Troll.

This was what she’d been practicing for! Ceria raised her finger, aiming for the Troll’s vulnerable eyes—

And felt something crash into the back of her head. She stumbled, and the world went dark. Something had hit her. But this was a test. What—?

“That damn brat! He hit the half-Elf on purpose!”

Some of the mages were calling out in outrage. Rievan was raising his voice, trying to placate them.

“It was an accident. A slip of the finger!”

“Was this your plan? If this is what the Libertarians call fair, I won’t have it! I demand a retrial!”

“Now? You’ve got to be joking. We saw the half-Elf go down by accident.”

“My tail it was an accident!”

“It’s too late to retry. We’ll just have to judge her by what we’ve seen. That’s fair. And as for that boy, I doubt he’s passing.”

“He’ll just buy his way in! This is outrageous—”

Rievan let the debate rage hotly among the other mages, sometimes shouting in support, but no longer trying to shift the argument. It was done. Ceria was lying on the ground. She couldn’t distinguish herself further in this trial. A redo of the test was unlikely, he knew. Some mages might shout, but no one wanted to give one student special treatment.

He stared at the examinees, smiling, but his smile faded when he saw what was going on. Illphres shifted her cold stare from Rievan to the

students still battling the illusions. She passed a hand over her mouth, and then she was smiling.

Pain. Dark. Ceria felt herself falling—

And someone caught her halfway down. Ceria felt two arms encircling her, and felt herself being lifted upwards. She felt...safe. Someone was calling her name. Ceria smiled. So dark.

The world faded. When Ceria opened her eyes again, the exam was over. But in the time between then, someone carried her.

“That boy. What’s he doing?”

“He can’t be intending to carry the half-Elf to the end?”

The mages stared as Pisces lifted Ceria, dodging out of the way of the Troll’s illusory club. The Lizardwoman angrily turned towards a group of mages Rievan was standing with.

“See what’s happened? Now we’ll have to adjust for his performance as well. He can’t be expected to do as well carrying her!”

“What if we send a mage in to retrieve her? That’s simple.”

“Yes, but—wait a second. What’s that in his hands?”

The mages stared. After a moment one exclaimed.

“A rapier? Why’s he carrying *that*?”

“We *told* them it was a combat test. And I suppose some of them heard the rumor about the Troll—”

“If he wants to try and take it out with a rapier, that’s fine. But that’s not a display of mage combat—”

“Hold on!”

Some of the mages gasped as they saw Pisces blur with Ceria’s body in his hands. He stabbed backwards as the Troll lunged at him, and then ran the hulking beast through with his rapier. On one shoulder he carried Ceria’s unconscious body, in the other hand he held the rapier, thrusting it into the Troll’s eye.

“Good strike!”

“Look at that footwork! The Troll can’t touch him! He’ll take it down without a scratch!”

“That [Flash Step] spell is being used superbly! Does he have any [Warrior] classes?”

“He doesn’t need any. Look at his rapier.”

That comment came from Illphres. The mages stared, and after a second one exclaimed.

“A silver bell! Well, that explains that. If we’re looking at a [Swordmage] here, I say we accept him on the spot.”

“Even if he doesn’t want to be one, this is a splendid example of mixing magic with conventional proficiencies. I agree!”

Rievan stared helplessly as he watched Pisces run past the disintegrating Troll. Weapon in hand, the young man was speeding through the rest of the test almost too fast for the mages in charge to trigger the spells.

“Silver bell? What’s so important about a silver bell?”

“It means he is recognized as a true expert. It’s a Terandrian symbol of expertise.”

Rievan jumped. He turned and stepped backwards from Illphres. She was smiling at him and he didn’t like it.

“Indeed, Miss Illphres?”

“Yes.”

She nodded at Pisces.

“He doesn’t have to have a [Fencer] class. A silver bell is given to those who reach a certain level in [Fencer], true, but it’s also given to those who have proven themselves by dueling a master. It’s worth a lot of money to some.”

She turned back to watch Pisces. Rievan clenched his fists, but he comforted himself with the thought that even if Pisces passed, his performance would only serve to eclipse Ceria’s. Regardless of whether she finished the test, she had done nothing.

And then the exams ended. Ceria woke up in her rooms two hours after it had finished, and cried a bit before Pisces and the others checked on her.

“It really wasn’t your fault, Ceria.”

Beatrice said that as they sat together in Ceria's room. It was hard to fit everyone in. Besides Pisces, Beatrice, and Calvaron, some of their friends and people they'd gotten to know had come, like Cessic, to cheer Ceria up.

The room was crowded, especially with Calvaron in it. He kept turning and finding nowhere to go. Now he stomped one hoof angrily.

"It was that bastard Charles! I wouldn't have believed he would try anything—the Libertarians have really done it now! There's a row happening and I'll protest what he did to the Council."

"I will too. But the mages won't redo the test, Calvaron."

The Centaur deflated slightly.

"No. They won't. I'm sorry, Ceria. But they saw you during the first part, and you did really well."

"Yes, you did. And I'm sure they'll take note."

Ceria tried to smile, and failed. She looked at Pisces. He was avoiding her gaze, toying awkwardly with the rapier in his hands.

"I hear you carried me all the way to the end. Thank you, Pisces."

"And he set a record doing it! Dead gods, I heard about it! Some mages are using a [Mind Scene] spell to show others—Pisces was dodging traps left and right! He barely got touched by any! He'll be sure to pass—"

Calvaron broke off, awkwardly. All the other students in the room fell silent, but Ceria already knew the truth. She looked at Pisces.

"Thank you. I'm glad you did it. And I'm glad you'll pass. You deserve—you deserve to be here."

Ceria choked on the words. She felt like someone was tearing out her guts. Beatrice patted her softly on the shoulder.

"You don't know you failed. You did as well as anyone else. Better, in many parts."

But Ceria knew it was over. She knew it in her heart. She bore with the words of comfort and vows against Charles and the Libertarian party as long as she could, and then excused herself. Beatrice and Pisces offered to go with her, but Calvaron managed to get them to leave Ceria alone, which she was grateful for.

All she wanted to be was alone. She'd failed. Her big chance had been right in front of her—

And she'd failed.

Ceria stumbled down the corridors of Wistrum, deserted except for the occasional golem or older mage. All the students were celebrating or

commiserating with one another. She used one cold stone wall for support as she wandering aimlessly.

It wasn't fair. Part of Ceria was raging. She wanted to kill Charles for attacking her. But why hadn't she been ready? Why hadn't she guessed he'd do something like this and taken precautions? She could have learned a barrier spell, or watched her back—

“Stupid!”

Ceria pounded her fist into a wall. She hit it again and again until her knuckles bled, but it didn't help. Ceria walked on, full of despair. She wiped at her eyes and saw her tears mix with the blood.

She wondered if she could ask Pisces for the spellbook when she left. Maybe he'd let her take it. That way, at least she wouldn't have done all this for nothing.

It was cold. Ceria shivered, and then looked up. She looked at a wall of ice, uncomprehending, until she stared about and realized where she was. Her path had taken her to the classrooms where they normally studied.

This was the classroom Illphres had blocked off.

“Get through if you're a real mage and I'll teach you, huh?”

Ceria spat bitterly and raised her fist to punch the icy wall. But it would just freeze her skin and probably tear it off. She glared at the icy wall.

It wasn't that cold. It was just ice, but Illphres had made it impossible to break or melt. It was an unfair test, just like the rest of Wistram.

Unfair. But what could she do about it? By now, Ceria knew Calvaron would have talked everyone into doing a bit of celebrating. She dreaded going to his room, where the party would be going on. He'd probably be pouring everyone a drink and showing them how to put salt on their stupid glasses—

Wait a second. Ceria stopped as she had a thought. It was crazy, but... her eyes widened and Ceria dashed off through the halls.

“You need *what*?”

Calvaron stared at Ceria as she panted and tried to explain. He and Beatrice were standing outside of the large room they'd chosen to party in. Ceria could hear loud voices through the stone walls, but she had no time for drinking.

“Please, Calvaron. I need to take some stuff out of the kitchens, but the [Cook] there said I needed to get permission from the head [Chef] or pay. And I don’t have the coin! Please—I’ll pay you back.”

“Can it wait? We’re celebrating, Ceria! You should too!”

Calvaron stared back towards the party. He pointed into the room.

“Pisces is already drunk. I had to practically pour a bottle of wine down his throat so he wouldn’t go looking for you. Come on, whatever it is, it can wait!”

“No, it can’t. Please, Calvaron. I know I don’t have anything I can trade you, but—”

Beatrice looked at Ceria’s pleading face, and then nudged Calvaron. He blew out his cheeks, but nodded.

“Oh—fine! Tell the [Cook] that you can take whatever you need. Put it on my account.”

“Thank you! Thank you! Tell Pisces I’m fine! I’ve just got to go!”

Ceria raced off. Calvaron watched her go and turned to Beatrice.

“What in the name of the Great Companies was that, do you think?”

Beatrice shrugged. She stared at the place where Ceria had been.

“Should we go after her? She’s very upset.”

“I don’t know. No—she’s got a plan. We’d better let her do what she needs to do and not draw attention. But see if the bookies will take another bet, will you? I’m thinking our dear Springwalker might have better odds than we think.”

Wistram was quiet the day after the exams. Most students and mages were too hungover to do anything, and the ones who weren’t suffering were disinclined to do anything when making loud noises could get half a dozen spells cast at your face. Thus, it was only a few mages who gathered outside to practice their spells by the ocean.

Illphres was raising pillars of ice and shattering them with the [Glacial Spear] spell when Ceria found her. The half-Elf panted as she raised a hand to touch Illphres.

“Miss Illphres—”

The woman turned faster than Ceria had ever seen her and stopped Ceria.

“Do not touch me. What is it?”

“Please, come with me.”

“Why?”

Illphres stared expressionlessly at Ceria. The half-Elf knew she was disheveled, hair mussed, and she knew she was grimy and still damp to boot. She tried to explain.

“I did it. I did it. I got rid of the ice just like you said so can you come and see? So I can show you? The ice?”

For a second Illphres just stared at Ceria, but then she nodded.

“Very well. Show me.”

No one was using the classrooms when Ceria led Illphres there. She had to slow her pace so Illphres could follow, although Ceria was bursting with impatience. Illphres didn’t move faster than a walk. The ice mage stopped though, when she saw the dripping hole in her ice wall.

“Hm.”

“I did it, you see?”

Ceria practically danced in front of the melted ice, half-hysterical from exhaustion. She waved her arms and nearly cried out. Her muscles were beyond burning—they felt torn, and her fingers and hands were raw and practically numb.

Illphres gazed at Ceria and then at the wall. She stared hard at the puddle on the stone ground, and noted the white stains on the floor. She looked at Ceria calmly and said one word.

“Salt.”

“Yes, salt!”

Ceria pointed triumphantly to the nearly empty bag of salt, a huge sack she’d practically depleted after she’d taken it from Wistram’s kitchens. It was so simple. Salt.

Salt melted ice. Ceria had used it to melt the ice, rubbing it on the frozen spell over and over and raising the heat with her own spells. She’d thought it was hopeless, but slowly, oh so slowly, the salt had helped dissolve the enchanted ice.

“I created this ice wall to be impervious to any spells below Tier 4. But I didn’t expect anyone to actually use something like salt.”

Illphres mused as she stared at the gap in her ice wall. Ceria stared at her, hopefully, desperately.

“But I thought of it. It’s not magic, but you didn’t say I couldn’t use salt. So I pass, don’t I? You’ll teach me spells?”

“There’s only three days before your probationary period ends.”

Illphres turned to Ceria, expressionless. Ceria’s heart sank, and then the anger in her bubbled forth.

“So? You said anyone who could get into your classroom you’ll teach magic! I’ll go in right now if you want!”

“Spare me. But what kind of a mage uses *salt*?”

“Me! I did it! I’ll do anything to learn magic.”

“So I see.”

“Please, teach me magic. I might not stay here, but I want to learn *something* powerful. Please, you promised!”

Ceria found herself begging to Illphres and hated herself for it, but she was at the end of her rope. This was the only thing she could think of, the last straw she had to grasp at. If Illphres would teach her something, maybe Ceria could earn money as an adventurer and try again next year. Or if she didn’t, she’d at least have something from Wistram.

For a long time the ice mage was silent. Her face was cold, like a mask, and Ceria could read nothing in her expression. For her part, Illphres looked the half-Elf in front of her up and down.

Ceria was as old or older than Illphres was but still a young woman by her people’s standards. Her hands were red, the knuckles and skin on her palms cracked and bleeding from the intense cold and friction. She was desperate, begging.

Illphres looked at the ice wall, the wall she’d created, sure that no student could break it on their own. Melted, not with a spell, but with salt and effort.

“Tell me, girl. What makes you think a real mage would stoop to this? A real mage would strive towards the height of magic on her own, not rely on anyone else.”

In front of her, Ceria took a deep shuddering breath. She looked up at Illphres, and there was a spark in her eyes of something more than determination.

“I know that. But I can’t become a real mage on my own. You told me that real mages don’t need help. To forge my own path. Well, I found a way

to melt your damn ice, but I still need help. I want to *become* a real mage, but I'm not going to be able to stay here. So teach me something now. Please."

Silence. Illphres stared at Ceria, and then nodded.

"Interesting."

That was all. She turned away and began to walk from her classroom. Ceria jumped as the ice blocking it reformed in an instant. She called out to Illphres in despair.

"Wait! Where are you going?"

The ice mage made no reply. She walked away, and Ceria sunk to her knees in the cold corridor.

That was it. It was over.

Slowly, Ceria made her way back to her room. She crawled into bed and slept, too full of sadness to cry. She slept as she heard students stumbling outside of her door, slept and willed herself never to wake.

But someone did wake her. Someone hammered at her door and shouted when Ceria didn't respond.

"Ceria! *Ceria!* Are you in there? Get up! You passed! You did it! You *passed!*"

"What?"

Ceria leapt out of bed. She shoved open the door and nearly ran Pisces over. He gabbled at her and then gave up and both of them ran down the corridors, past students celebrating and crying and hugging each other. They came to the entrance hall and stared up at the floating words that danced and spun about in the massive room.

It was a list. A list of names. Each one was a student. Ceria saw Pisces' name on there, no last name given, and Charles de Trevalier's, and Timon's too. But she had no time for that. She looked up and down the list desperately, and then saw her name. It was right on the end, hovering in the air, slightly out of place, as if tacked on at the last minute.

Ceria Springwalker.

Ceria didn't know what happened after that. She had a brief image of herself kissing Pisces on the cheek, hugging him, and then running to find Calvaron and Beatrice and hugging and crying some more. She only knew

that at some point after the banquet and speeches and eating she found Illphres. Or rather, the mage found her.

The bathrooms in Wistram were magical as with everything else, but Ceria was far too drunk to appreciate them at the moment. She staggered out of one and nearly ran into Illphres. The ice mage was waiting for her, and scaring away all the other students who wanted to use the bathroom.

“I keep my promises.”

That was all she said. Ceria stared at her, and burst into tears. Illphres looked slightly surprised. That was to say, her eyes widened, although the lower half of her face didn’t change.

“Stop that.”

“Thank you!”

“Don’t thank me. You broke my enchantment.”

“But you—you—”

Ceria sniveled and Illphres rolled her eyes.

“Tomorrow, class will be held in my quarters. Find your way there. Do not be drunk or late. If any of your friends manage to melt the ice I will teach them too.”

“Pisces will come.”

Ceria said that instantly. Illphres paused.

“I see. Will all the other students come? It is a valuable...secret you have. It might be worth much. What will you do with it, let everyone pass my test?”

“I don’t know. I don’t know what I’ll do with it. I owe someone—but Pisces will come.”

“So you will help your friend, to pass my test? I wonder, will you drag yourself down by pulling other people up?”

It was a question that wasn’t really a question, but Ceria had an answer ready. She smiled through watery eyes at Illphres.

“Real mages help each other. We don’t abandon each other.”

The ice mage stared at Ceria for a long time. Then she passed a hand over the lower half of her face, obscuring her mouth. When she lowered her hand, Ceria saw she was smiling ever so slightly.

“So I’ve noticed.”

She turned and walked away. Ceria smiled at her back, and bowed ever so slightly. Then she ran to find Pisces. She had to drink more, and tell him—and maybe Calvaron—everything. After all, she didn’t want to be in

Illphres' class alone tomorrow. She wanted to learn everything with Pisces.
At last, they had time.

At last, they were true mages of Wistram.

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Wistram Days (Pt.5)

Of the many wonders of the world, the isle of Wistram and the academy of mages which rests upon it is not, in fact, one of the greatest. It is not the oldest relic of the past, not by far. The tall, dark citadel of stone does not shine with the colors of a thousand glittering ores smelted into metal like the fabled Dwarf-built towers in Baleros.

And neither is Wistram associated with power, at least not more so than any other ancient structure. The Walled Cities of Izril speak of an era long past, when Drakes fought their distant ancestors from atop those battlements. It is not the oldest building made, nor the grandest, nor is it the most isolated.

And yet, for every young mage in the world, no other place could capture their hearts so. Wistram Academy represents the pinnacle of magic learning and ambition. To them, it is a long-pursued dream, and to spend just a moment in those fabled halls is what some will work towards their entire lives.

Which is why leaving is all the harder. The day after the yearly exams finished, the isle of Wistram saw a slight increase in the number of seafaring vessels docking in its stone harbor. Experienced [Captains] chartered from around the world made their way to Wistram to pick up the failed students. Of the hundreds who had come, as usual, less than a tenth had passed.

The students departed silently, some weeping, others too disappointed for words. They stared at Wistram as the ships took them out of the calm bubble around the isle. As the winds and rain descended, the gray spires of Wistram's citadel would be the last thing they saw.

That is what those who had failed saw. For those who passed, their celebration was nearing its third consecutive day.

It has to be said that mages know how to party. Aside from being able to obtain delicacies and goods from around the world, the students at Wistram

had developed quite a number of spells specifically designed to add to a party. Some were amusing, like a spell that disguised a drink's true nature until it had been imbibed. Others were simply dangerous, as in the case of one party which saw students play a game where they aimed spells at a moving target. Fifteen students were badly injured and one nearly died.

However, on the third day the partying had ceased to become an all-day affair, and life was returning to normal, although the night's entertainment was rumored to be better than last year's. For now though, the newly accepted students stumbled into the banquet hall to eat before class. Some of them jumped in surprise when they heard the cheering from the older students, and several of them flushed red with embarrassment. They were full students of Wistram now.

"Aw, look at them. They're so awkward. It reminds me of you two when you passed."

Calvaron laughed as he sat at his customary table with Beatrice, Ceria, and Pisces. The others glanced up as they noted the new students streaming into the hall. Beatrice stopped spooning porridge into her mouth and turned her head to look, and Ceria did likewise. Pisces was still engrossed in his book.

"How many passed this year?"

"Thirty-four."

Beatrice answered this time. She frowned as a trio of people—Drake, Human, and Lizardman – passed by. They all had deathly pale bodies and they were clearly Selphids.

"Lots of Selphids this year."

"So? Don't glare, Beatrice. You'll scare them."

Calvaron grinned as Beatrice looked away. She turned her head to continue feeding herself, and Ceria nudged Pisces.

"Hey. Get your head out of the spellbook and take a look."

"What?"

At last, Pisces blinked and looked up with a frown. He took in the new students being jeered, laughed at, and congratulated and blinked.

"Oh, are the exams over? That was quick."

"Yes, it was. Stop reading and eat with us."

Ceria yanked the worn spellbook out of Pisces' hands. He protested, but gave in and pulled the cold plate of sausages and potatoes over towards him.

“You interrupted me just as I thought I was getting towards a breakthrough. I was close to figuring out the [Invisibility] spell, I’m sure of it!”

“You’ve been saying that all month. One break’s not going to kill you so shut up and eat.”

The half-Elf rolled her eyes as she levitated a tureen of gravy over while Pisces warmed his food up with a simple heat spell. In moments he was happily scarfing down his food.

Calvaron sighed and shook his head as he stared at the two second-year students sadly.

“It’s so sad.”

“Don’t start, Calvaron.”

“No, no! I have to say this.”

The Centaur pretended to be deeply troubled, sighing and clutching at his chest.

“I can’t bear to see it. How quickly you two become jaded – it feels like just yesterday you two were eager students, so happy to be admitted to Wistram! Didn’t you, Ceria, burst into tears at the table one year ago? And you, Pisces, I fondly recall you getting so drunk you thought you could cast the [Flight] spell and leaping off your balcony—”

He ducked as Ceria hurled one of Pisces’ sausages at him. Beatrice raised her head so she could glare at everyone.

“Stop that. Behave.”

Calvaron raised his hands and Ceria went back to her food. Pisces was busy eating. The four students were used to each other’s company after a year of studying together, and so in no time they were talking about the latest world news and gossiping over publicly available secrets. But Calvaron stopped and turned his head as someone new approached their table.

“Um, excuse me. Do you mind if I sit with you?”

Ceria paused as she reached for her goblet of milk, chewing a huge bite of sausage. She saw a young Human staring anxiously at her, a young woman to be exact, bright red hair hanging in a loose ponytail down the robes on her back.

“Why certainly, miss. Have a seat, please!”

Calvaron ushered the young woman to one of the padded chairs that went well with the low table. He waggled his fingers at Ceria and she

shoved Pisces' plate over to make room, much to his displeasure.

"Ceria, I'm *eating*—"

Pisces looked up and took in the new arrival. He coughed, and wiped his mouth with a napkin.

"Ah, excuse me. Who is this?"

"My name is Montressa du Valeross. I'm a first-year student here."

The young woman bowed her head slightly, practically radiating nervousness. She seemed intimidated by the older students, especially Beatrice, who was regarding her with her usual calm. Ceria found that amusing, and noted the slight smile on Calvaron's face.

"Please, sit, Montressa. Are you here for me, or something else? I'm afraid I don't have that many secrets to buy at the moment, but if you're looking to sell a few—"

"Secrets? Oh—I mean, no. I'd just like to sit and talk and—"

Montressa stumbled over her words. Calvaron just laughed though, and with his usual charm broke through her awkwardness.

"Oh, just talk is it? Well, I'm good at talking. You're one of the students who just passed the exam? Congratulations! Don't let my dour companions put you off—Beatrice stares at everyone, Ceria's always grumpy and Pisces doesn't see anything when he's eating."

He winced as a napkin, sausage, and pinch of salt bounced off his chest. Montressa laughed, covered her mouth, and thus became part of the table.

"So, why are you here Montressa?"

Calvaron asked that after the young woman had begun eating the food she'd brought. Ceria saw her pause as she lifted a forkful of buttered peas to her mouth. Montressa put her fork down and glanced at Ceria and Pisces before replying.

"Well, I'm ah, new here. And I was just accepted to Wistram, but I actually didn't take the exams. I got in late you see; I've only been studying for a week now."

Ceria saw Pisces' eyebrows rise and she blinked in astonishment herself. But Calvaron only nodded as if it were obvious.

"Your family paid the full fees for this year? Well, no wonder Wistram accepted you."

Montressa blushed.

"I wanted to take the exam, but I wouldn't have passed and I missed the first ship you see—"

“Don’t worry about it. A student’s a student. It’s just your good fortune you *could* afford to pay your way in.”

Ceria frowned.

“Du Valeross? Oh, you’re one of the Terandrian nobility, aren’t you? You wouldn’t happen to know Timor du Havrington, would you?”

“Me? No. I mean, I know of his family, but I haven’t talked to any of them.”

“Good. Otherwise we’d have to kick you out of the table.”

Calvaron smiled to allay the girl’s sudden panic.

“Don’t worry. It’s nothing you’ve done. It’s just that Ceria and Pisces here don’t get along with Timor du Havrington or his friends. I’d suggest you stay away from him as well. He’s a bad egg, you know. And let me tell you, there’s nothing like a bad egg to spoil an omelette.”

Montressa nodded seriously, and Ceria had to pinch herself hard not to burst out laughing. She saw the same humor in Pisces and Beatrice’s eyes; Montressa was so earnest she was taking Calvaron seriously.

They kept eating. Montressa explained that she was an aspiring mage—she’d been tutored since she was young, but to really start her education she’d been sent to Wistram by her family.

“My parents are of the lesser Terandrian nobility. They want me to become a great mage and apparently I have the aptitude, so they made a gift to Wistram for my enrollment.”

“And no doubt you’ve been approached by all the factions already. I hope you didn’t commit.”

The young woman nodded nervously.

“I was told to avoid making promises. And I’m just learning my way around here still—I only found out about secrets yesterday. I don’t want to take sides, just study.”

“Good luck.”

Pisces sighed, and Ceria made a face. She was still independent after a year, as was he. But pressure on them was mounting too.

“So you’re a new, keen student. That makes sense, but I have to ask, why sit with us? We’re happy to have you, but you seem to have approached us for a reason.”

Montressa fiddled with her fork.

“I um, heard you all were really good mages. I didn’t study with the other students for the first month, so I’m really behind—I was hoping I

could ask one of you to tutor me. I could pay, but I don't have *that* much coin on me and I don't have any secrets, so..."

The older students fell silent. Calvaron stroked his chin as he glanced at Beatrice. She smiled slightly and nodded a bit—Ceria shrugged and poked Pisces. He was busy eating and didn't notice.

"Well, Pisces here is probably the best for that."

Pisces looked up.

"Me?"

"Yes, you. Why don't you help young Montressa with her studies?"

The young man swept a hand through his messy hair, looking distracted.

"Well, I *am* studying my [Invisibility] spell at the moment. It would be a time commitment but I...hm. I don't think I'd fall behind in my own classes —"

"I'll pay you. Four small secrets for helping, how about that?"

Montressa opened her mouth to protest as Pisces sat up and nodded. Calvaron waggled a finger at her.

"Ah, ah. Don't object. You're new and I have a soft spot for new students. After all—"

He clutched at his chest as Ceria rolled her eyes and smiled.

"—You're only young once. Besides, Pisces really is the best mage in Wistram to help you."

"Really?"

"Oh yes. Don't you know who you're sitting across from? Pisces—wipe your mouth, Pisces—is a hero, nay, *legend* among his fellow students."

Montressa's mouth fell open as Ceria tried desperately not to burst out laughing. Calvaron continued, eyes twinkling.

"Do you know he finished his first-year exams by killing a Troll? He was passed unanimously by all the mages. He actually *got* money from Wistram to stay, if you can believe that. A natural genius; he's the best second-year student at dueling, and debate *and* he's one of only six students to have passed the Ice Demon's class last year."

"Ice Demon? I heard the class last year was hard, but the teacher for this year is nice. Who is the 'Ice Demon'? Is she actually a demon? From Rhir?"

"Close, but even those demons would probably run from Illphres. You might know her as the grumpy Human who never smiles at anyone. She specializes in ice magic—she had to teach a class in combat magic last year,

but it was so grueling that everyone who managed to take it dropped out. Only six students passed. Two of them are sitting at this table.”

Pisces straightened up importantly, and Ceria waved a hand. Montressa turned huge eyes to her. It was too much. Ceria stood up, balancing her dishes on top of one another.

“I’ve got to go. Don’t tell Montressa too many lies, Calvaron.”

He looked offended.

“Lies? Not at all. I may exaggerate the truth, but believe me, Miss Montressa, every word I say is absolutely true. Good luck, Ceria!”

She waved at him as she left the table. Pisces was still eating and he wagged his fingers at her. Ceria left, striding purposefully out of the banquet hall.

The Ice Demon? Is that what people were calling Illphres nowadays? Ceria supposed the nickname had started last year when she was teaching. It wasn’t entirely undeserved.

Balancing on poles while firing magic at oncoming targets, learning to cast while in pain or under stress, aiming at targets that were invisible – in the days after Ceria had won the right to take Illphres’ class, she’d sometimes wished she’d failed the exam altogether. Although she’d traded the knowledge of how to pass Illphres’ test to Calvaron for a good price—as payment for him helping her get the salt in the first place—almost all of the students who took Illphres’ class still dropped out.

The woman was vindictive, mean, uncaring, and frankly, rude. She’d made each student melt the ice with the salt by themselves while she watched, which eliminated over half who simply gave up from sheer exhaustion. And yet, Ceria had leveled up more from her tutelage than anyone else’s.

That was why Ceria stopped in front of the door that was lined with frost two floors up from the banquet hall and waited. She knew better than to knock; Illphres’ room was so cold that the door could tear the skin off of the palm of your hand. Nor did she try to get Illphres’ attention by shouting or calling out. If Illphres knew she was here, she probably wouldn’t come out.

Ceria was fairly confident Illphres hadn’t gone to breakfast yet, and sure enough, after only fifteen minutes or so of waiting, the door opened. The expressionless woman with dark hair paused when she saw Ceria. The half-Elf stared innocently back at her.

“Good morning, Miss Illphres.”

The woman just stared at her. Illphres sighed, and then walked out into the corridor. She moved past Ceria without a word, walking slowly and somewhat stiffly down the hallway. Students and some mages moved aside when they saw her, but Ceria just caught up to Illphres and began chatting naturally.

“I gained a new class today.”

“Oh?”

Illphres’ voice contained not a shred of interest. Ceria smiled cheerfully, forcing her mouth to move upwards.

“Yeah, I gained the [Elementalist] class.”

“How interesting.”

“I think it’s a good start, don’t you? It’s better than being a general [Mage], at any rate.”

“An [Elementalist] is just a mage who can’t commit to one specific element.”

That stung and made the smile on Ceria’s face falter, but she didn’t stop.

“Well...it’s still a class change. And I owe it all to you.”

“Do you?”

“You taught me how to improve my magic. You helped me learn so much last year. And you know, I *am* a second-year student now.”

“So I understand.”

“And I don’t have a master right now and I could really use some magical instruction...”

“And?”

She was going to make Ceria say it again. The half-Elf took a breath.

“Teach me magic.”

“No.”

“You did it last year.”

“Because I had to.”

“I would really like you to be my master. Please?”

“No.”

“Can I change your mind?”

“No.”

“What if I got you breakfast?”

“No.”

“What would you like to eat today? They’ve got mashed potatoes and sausage, but there’s also quite a good spread of greens today if you want—”

“Go away.”

“If you taught me magic, I’m sure I could help you out so much.”

“No.”

“Please?”

“No.”

“Pretty please?”

“No.”

“What if I—”

“No.”

Ceria didn’t get Illphres to teach her magic that day. Or the next. Or the next. But every day she found herself standing outside of Illphres’ door, and every day the ice mage looked more and more annoyed to find Ceria standing there. But she never wavered, and Ceria never gave up trying to persuade her, much to the amusement of her friends.

“It’s not exactly uncommon, what Ceria’s doing. She needs a master, you see. Someone to teach her magic.”

Calvaron explained to Montressa as the young woman sat with them and studied. She’d quickly become a part of their group and sat with them when the students ate or studied—usually in Calvaron’s room. She was earnest, enthusiastic, and, Ceria was happy to find, not at all bothered by other species. She treated Ceria exactly the same as Pisces, which was a refreshing change of pace.

“Do all second-year students have to get a mage to teach them?”

Montressa, or Mons as everyone had grown to call her, looked up from her spellbook as Pisces muttered to himself and frowned over his spellbook. He’d managed to figure out how to turn himself transparent, but that was a far cry from true [Invisibility].

“Not at all.”

Calvaron shook his head and sat up importantly. He gestured to Beatrice, who was sitting next to him and leaning against his lower half. They were sharing a blanket.

“You see, older students like Beatrice and I, well, we *have* to have masters because it’s simply too hard to progress otherwise. There’s a limited number of spellbooks and besides, older mages can help us in so many ways.”

“But it’s hard. Masters don’t always need apprentices.”

“Exactly, thank you Beatrice. Many mages don’t want to have to teach younger mages, so we have to persuade them. Sometimes it’s with services we can provide—I can get my master almost anything he needs thanks to my connections and Beatrice helps her master with his spells. But it’s all variable. Some mages like my master have multiple apprentices and teach them all, and others have only one like Beatrice’s.”

“And some don’t want apprentices. Like Illphres.”

“But if she doesn’t want one, then why—”

“Ah, well, only Ceria could tell you why anyone would be crazy enough to want Illphres as a teacher.”

Ceria raised her head from her spellbook and scowled at Calvaron.

“I think she’s an excellent mage, okay? And I want a master who knows actual combat magic. Illphres is the only mage I actually know, and I think I can convince her.”

Calvaron winked at Mons.

“There’s a running bet on. Fifty-to-one says Ceria doesn’t manage it by the end of the year. But she’s doing her best, and it’s been done before. Bothering the older mages constantly is a valid tactic.”

“So long as she doesn’t freeze Ceria’s ears off.”

“She wouldn’t do *that*, would she?”

Ceria just shrugged.

“She might. But I think she likes me.”

The first month had passed in the blink of an eye, and the second was almost over as Ceria walked through the hallways of Wistram. She was looking for Pisces so they could get together and study after their class on enchantments. She passed by students and mages, nodding to some, smiling at others, wondering where Pisces had run off to.

This was Ceria’s life in her second year at Wistram. A lot had changed, but much had stayed the same. She still took classes, although they were

harder, and she actively pestered Illphres every time she saw her. Being a second-year student only meant you studied more; a student was still a student and Ceria had already gotten used to classes and practicing spells day in and day out.

But one thing was different. Ceria found Pisces by following the excited voices. She heard a roar as she pushed her way through a crowd of students and saw Pisces, rapier in hand, pointing it at another young man who had both hands raised.

“My victory, Ramon.”

Pisces smiled at the third-year student. The other mage flushed bright red, but he reluctantly dropped the sword and wand in his hands.

“That was unfair! I never saw—”

“A victory’s a victory. Pay up.”

Pisces didn’t lower his rapier until Ramon tore a pouch from his belt and hurled it at him. The bag slowed in midair and Pisces snagged it. He sheathed his rapier with a flourish as the crowd began to break up. Ramon stomped away towards another group of Humans who glared at Ceria as she approached.

“Another duel? Dead gods, how many is that this week, Pisces? Six?”

“Eight, in fact. And you won’t believe how much I won this time. Six gold pieces and ten silver.”

Ceria whistled as she fell into step beside him. Pisces grinned widely as he added the coins to his bulging purse. He had come to this academy poor, but now he was rich in both coin and secrets.

“They must have been very certain they’d beat you this time. What did that Ramon fellow have? A wand?”

Pisces nodded.

“A dancing sword enchantment on one of the daggers and he had a wand with a frost spell attuned to it. He must have thought he could corner me with his sword, but he’s a poor fighter. It was a simple victory.”

“In that case, you’re paying for drinks tonight. Come on, I want to go over what we learned in class. Let’s go.”

Pisces frowned as he stowed his money pouch at his side.

“Where? A library? I told you I prefer solitude. Our rooms are back that way, if you recall.”

“Don’t be stupid. Montressa invited us to her room, remember? And it’s a lot less messy than yours and far bigger than mine.”

“Oh. Of course.”

It was now Ceria and Pisces’ custom to study with Montressa if Calvaron and Beatrice were busy. And the two older students often were. Aside from their more difficult classes, the two were officially an item now, which came as no surprise to anyone that knew them. Calvaron’s obvious affection for Beatrice made Ceria sick sometimes; not the affection itself mind, but the lavish compliments he heaped on her every second.

Pisces sniffed as he adjusted his robes. Ceria eyed him as she walked.

“You need to wash your robes again, or learn a cleaning spell, Pisces. Dead gods, if you can learn [Invisibility] in one month you’d think you could look up [Cleanse] or something!”

He looked down at his robes with a frown.

“I don’t think they’re *that* dirty.”

“I can see stains all over them! Go buy some new ones—I’m sure Calvaron could find you some nice ones enchanted against messes.”

“I prefer to save my coin for more important things.”

“Like what?”

“Spellbooks, Springwalker, spellbooks. Even with what I can earn in duels, obtaining a new spellbook will be extremely expensive. I need to save all the secrets and coin I can. Why, a wand would set me back—”

“Just don’t be surprised if Montressa kicks you out of her room for being too messy.”

“She wouldn’t do that, surely?”

Pisces looked worried. Ceria paused.

“No, I don’t think she would. She likes you, I think.”

“Really?”

He brightened. Ceria made a face at him.

“You can’t tell? It’s pretty obvious. And don’t tell me you haven’t seen Praemla making eyes at you in class.”

“Well, I—I might have seen, but you know—”

There was no accounting for taste. Pisces grew flustered as Ceria kept teasing him. He was fairly popular with the female sex it seemed, if only because he was a genius at magic. Ceria could only roll her eyes when someone brought Pisces up as a potential boyfriend. He was far too messy, distracted, and besides—

She poked him in the back. Pisces yelped and glared.

“What?”

“There’s rat dropping on your robes, Pisces! How have you not cleared those things out yet?”

“As a matter of fact, those are *mice* droppings, Ceria. I happened to run across a few briefly earlier this week.”

“Again? Do you seek out rodents in your spare time or something?”

“I—”

He faltered. Ceria glanced sharply at him.

This is what was different. In the time since they had become second-year students, Pisces had made a name for himself with his prowess in magic and dueling. He could beat students with several years on him thanks to his talent with a rapier. But he was also rich in secrets.

Very rich. In fact, Ceria sometimes wondered if Pisces had more secrets than Calvaron. It certainly seemed like Pisces knew everything sometimes. People could be whispering in the halls and he’d somehow pick up on it.

Naturally, everyone suspected Pisces of mastering an advanced eavesdropping spell, but no one could tell when he was using it or which spell it was. More than once Ceria had seen other students casting [Detect Magic] to try and observe him using the spell, but so far they—and she—hadn’t been able to figure out how Pisces was doing it.

“Something on your mind?”

“A bit.”

He turned down a corridor and Ceria saw him whisper a standard ward against listening. He kept talking casually with her, as if nothing had happened.

“You know, I’ve been meaning to speak with you, Ceria. There’s something I’d like to show you later.”

“Really? What?”

“A secret. A big one. Remember when we found the spellbook last year? Well—”

Pisces broke off and Ceria felt the ward around them vanish. He raised his voice and called out.

“Mons! Ah, good. We were just coming to see you.”

She hurried towards him, smiling widely, holding a stack of books in her arms. Ceria greeted Montressa and in a moment they were in her room.

Montressa had been given a large room—probably because her family had bought her way into Wistram. Ceria and Pisces sat at a wonderful table inlaid with ivory while they chatted in between periods of study.

“Did you go to Illphres again, Ceria? I can’t believe you stand outside her door every day!”

“It’s a habit. I think I’m getting to her—she’s started waking up earlier to try and avoid me.”

“I don’t see why she doesn’t turn you to ice. Everyone says she has a temper. She’s so scary!”

“Like I said, she likes me. And—uh, I think she might get in trouble if she does it. I hear she did it once and got in a lot of trouble with the Council. So I’m...probably...safe.”

“How many days has it been, Springwalker? Fifty six?”

“Yup. And I told you, stop calling me Springwalker, Pisces.”

He shrugged.

“As you wish. However, I must inquire. Isn’t there another mage with suitable qualifications that might serve as a master instead of Illphres?”

“There are. But they all already have apprentices or they’re like Illphres. I want a master who can teach me one-on-one, you know?”

Pisces and Montressa nodded. He frowned, tapping his fingers thoughtfully on the table.

“I support your efforts, but it would be prudent to have a fallback plan. Illphres is...”

“I know. If I can’t persuade her by the end of the year I’ll give up. Frankly, I hope I can get her to give in before that or passing the yearly tests is going to be tough.”

“Yearly tests? No one told me about yearly tests! I thought there were only the entrance exams for new students!”

Montressa sat up, looking alarmed. Pisces chuckled and waved a hand.

“You need not worry, Mons. You see, the yearly tests only apply to second-year students and beyond. And they’re not so much tests as... qualification exams.”

“That’s a test, Pisces.”

Ceria sighed and rubbed her head as she closed her spellbook. She tried to explain to Mons.

“You see, at the end of the year all mages have to prove they’ve learned something while studying at Wistram. It can be anything from a spell they’ve learned to reciting something they’ve studied or presenting something they’ve made—it’s just to prove they’re worth keeping. Otherwise the mage might be forced to pay to stay—it can be only a bit for

food and lodging, or a lot if the mage is a lazy waste of space like Charles de Trevalier.”

“Oh, I see.”

“Ceria doesn’t really need to worry that much, in truth, Mons. Second-year students don’t get tested nearly as harshly as older students like Calvaron and Beatrice.”

“That’s rich, coming from the mage who mastered [Invisibility] in one month.”

“Ah, well, all the better to spy with you see?”

“Just so long as you’re not caught peeping in any of the female students’ rooms, Pisces. I’ve heard some of them have learned anti-invisibility spells already.”

Pisces drew himself up indignantly.

“I would never stoop to such behavior! If you want to accuse anyone of voyeurism, try Quesm. You don’t think he’s taking scrying classes for purely academic reasons, do you?”

Both Mons and Ceria made noises of disgust. Talk turned back towards spells—this time on wards to prevent scrying and who might be willing to put them up in their rooms. Ceria never did get to ask what Pisces was going to say in the hallway, but she sometimes wondered if he would tell her.

She thought he would, eventually.

“There are more and more raids by pirates each week, it seems.”

Ceria pursued Illphres down the corridor. The mage ignored her. Doggedly, Ceria continued, trying to keep up a monologue.

“A lot of people think it’s the Drowned Men—not all of them obviously, but probably a few ships of them. They’re hitting all the major sailing routes, and some of the ships going to and from Wistram. Some nations have offered Wistram a reward if we destroy the ships. What do you think about that?”

“Pay for magic. That’s common. So what?”

“Well...I was thinking I might join in if the Council decides to send a hunting party. There’d probably be a lot of older students going, but it would be a good way to test my abilities in battle.”

Illphres turned her head to stare at Ceria.

“You? You wouldn’t last five minutes against a group of raiders.”

“Not by myself, but Wistram would hire a group of mercenaries and send a bunch of combat-capable students. Pisces said he might go. Calvaron and Beatrice wouldn’t, but it seems safe enough, don’t you think?”

“Arrogance.”

That was Illphres’ only comment. She walked out of the corridor and Ceria had to shade her eyes as she stepped out into the light. She found herself on a large walkway directly over the ocean.

This part of the citadel hung out over the calm seas. Ceria wondered why Illphres had come here. She stared down queasily into the water below. They were quite a ways out over the ocean—magic enabled the walkway to stretch far further than normal architectural engineering could allow.

Illphres stopped at the edge of the walkway. It had no guard rails, and so the mage could stare down straight into churning surf. She turned and passed a hand over her face. She was smirking a bit as Ceria halted a few steps back.

“You aren’t going to follow me over here like always?”

“I uh, don’t like heights that much.”

“I thought half-Elves all swung around on branches and lived in trees.”

“No, no...we don’t do that.”

Ceria cursed as her stomach roiled. Illphres was clearly enjoying herself. How had she found out Ceria was afraid of heights?

“Looks like the secret I paid for is true. You hate heights.”

“I—it’s more that I’m afraid of falling. Why did you come here?”

Illphres gestured to the open air around Ceria. She stared hard at the half-Elf.

“Four months you’ve followed me around. It’s annoying and you won’t stop.”

Ceria swallowed hard.

“No, no I won’t. Look, I know you don’t want an apprentice, but I need a master and you’re—well, brilliant. Please, won’t you teach me? I learned so much from you last year.”

Illphres considered this. She passed a hand over her face and her smile was slight and mischievous this time.

“I might. That’s why I’m testing you today.”

“A test?”

Ceria's ears perked up. She was going to be tested? She took a deep breath, hope fluttering in her chest.

"I'm willing to do whatever I need to."

"Really? Good. In that case—jump."

Illphres said the word lightly as she pointed down to the ocean below. Ceria's heart stopped.

"Wait, what?"

"Jump. And I'll make you my apprentice."

For a few seconds Ceria stared at Illphres. The woman was smiling at her. Just smiling.

"No. Hell no. That's stupid."

"Oh? I thought you'd do anything."

"I'm not an idiot. Who'd jump just because you said so?"

Ceria glared at Illphres. The woman looked amused. She shrugged and walked past Ceria.

"At least you're a bit intelligent. I wouldn't teach you if you did jump. Be careful not to slip."

"Slip? What do you m—"

Ceria turned to walk after Illphres and her foot slipped on a patch of ice. It was practically frictionless, and as Ceria windmilled her arms desperately and stepped back to keep her balance, her other foot slipped on a *second* patch of ice.

Screaming, she fell off the walkway down towards the ocean below. It was a long, long drop.

"Ceria, I really think you should stop. You did your best, but Illphres is never going to teach you."

That was what Calvaron said to her the next day as Ceria sat at their table, sneezing and shivering. She'd survived the fall, but gotten a bad cold from treading the freezing water before someone had helped levitate her out. Given that it was mid-summer, she had Illphres to thank for that as well.

Glowering, Ceria shook her head and coughed hard. Her lungs felt full of phlegm and she resented the way all the other students leaned away from her when she did.

“I’m not gibing up. And why are you all hiding?”

“I don’t want to get sick.”

Beatrice replied as she placed her head as far away from Ceria as possible. Pisces nodded. He turned to the young woman sitting beside him.

“Colds are impossible to cure with healing potions, Mons. You will note that Ceria remains this way even though she is in the capital of magic? The cold is so troublesome that the greatest of mages find themselves susceptible to it. It is simpler to let it run its course, but of course the risk of contagion from Ceria is—”

“Shut up.”

Ceria scowled at Pisces. She shivered; she still *felt* cold.

“Ib gonna make her teach me. I will.”

“Well, before you do that, would you mind convincing Pisces not to join the pirate hunting expedition? And removing yourself from the list as well?”

Calvaron snapped exasperatedly at the two. Beatrice nodded.

“It’s not safe. You shouldn’t go.”

“Nonsense. This is a prime opportunity.”

Pisces waved a hand airily.

“We have no less than *four* experienced captains with their own ships, each with a crew of capable fighters. And with over twenty of Wistram’s best students, we’ll be sure to find these pirates who have been preying on traffic and—”

“Get killed. Horribly. Or ransomed.”

Calvaron interrupted as he buttered a roll. Beatrice nodded her head with her hands.

“It’s dangerous.”

“Nonsense. You’re exaggerating things. Ceria and I will be paid handsomely—”

“If it’s so safe, why aren’t the mages doing it? Why leave it open to the students?”

The Centaur frowned at Pisces and Ceria. She coughed and replied.

“Because it’s boring? We’ll be days at sea and might not find them the first time. But it’s fine, really, Calvaron. We can handle ourselves.”

“I think you two shouldn’t go. I really do.”

Ceria just shook her head. Her mind was made up. Calvaron opened his mouth to argue again, and paused as something flickered and flew past his

face. He raised a hand to bat at it, and stopped as he saw the shimmering, fiery insect that flew past him to hover in front of Ceria.

She smiled as she saw the firefly—a literal fly made of glowing lights—hovering in the air. It spread its wings wide and she saw symbols and shapes flickering in the air.

“Oh? Is this from you, Mons?”

“I did it! I think I figured out the spell!”

Sitting next to Pisces, Mons’ face lit up with excitement. Calvaron stared at the flying insect and the message only Ceria could read and frowned.

“What’s this, Ceria?”

Pisces nodded. He straightened in his chair importantly as he explained.

“It’s a new spell Ceria and I developed. It helps us communicate at range and no one’s been able to decipher the messages.”

“So far.”

Beatrice studied the glowing message carefully. Pisces smiled confidently at her.

“I am sure no one will be able to break this spell. It is many times more complex than any [Message] spell you could ever devise, and it can be used up to several miles away.”

“Handy. Will you teach us how to use it?”

“Maybe...but only if you stop trying to dissuade Ceria and I. Our minds are made up.”

Calvaron threw up his hands in disgust.

“It’s your funeral.”

Two weeks later, Illphres found herself sitting alone at a table in the banquet hall. That was unusual for her, and she couldn’t help feeling something was wrong. Only when she understood that it was because she was used to having Ceria talking to her and pestering her did Illphres realize what she was unconsciously missing.

She passed a hand over her face and let her features change into a scowl. The half-Elf was gone on her adventure chasing pirates, and good riddance. She was far too annoying anyways, and now Illphres could concentrate.

That didn't improve her mood though, and neither did the tall Dullahan who pulled a chair up at the table with her. He was named Jurix, and he was part of her faction, the Isolationists. That didn't stop her from glaring daggers at him.

Jurix raised his hands as he placed his head on the table across from her. Two plates of food and a cup floated down next to it. He ignored Illphres' glare that told him to leave and began to talk to her, quite unperturbed. He was too cheerful for a Dullahan, which contrasted well with Illphres.

"Stop glaring, Illphres. We're on the same side here. Or are you missing that half-Elf that kept following you around all the time?"

"I'm not missing her and she was a pest. What do you want, Jurix?"

"Nothing. I'm just here to tell you that Ophelia is on board. Totally."

"Really?"

Illphres passed a hand over her mouth, and she was smiling when she lowered it. This was good news. Jurix nodded, pausing to smile as he fed himself with a hovering spoon.

"That's right. We've got four now; if we can get one more mage on our side I think we'll have a shot."

"I'll talk to Amerys again."

"Try not to start a fight?"

"No promises."

Illphres changed her features to a grin as she covered her mouth. She could have done it without covering her face; Jurix knew her secret. But she had grown used to doing it this way. She was about to ask Jurix what had changed Ophelia's mind when someone began shouting a few tables over.

"What's this now?"

Jurix frowned and picked up his head so he could see. Illphres turned and saw one of the mages shouting in panic as he raced into the room.

"It was a trap! They're under attack!"

"Who are?"

Someone shouted, and Illphres looked towards the entrances to the banquet hall. She was expecting another loose experiment, or perhaps some of the undead from the catacombs under Wistram, but it seemed the issue didn't lie within Wistram, but outside of it.

"The students! The hunting expedition we sent—it's been ambushed! I just received a [Message] spell—there's a fleet of nine ships attacking them! It's not just a few isolated ships—it's an entire armada!"

The banquet hall erupted into shouts at this news. Jurix turned to Illphres. Her expression hadn't changed, but her eyes had locked onto the mage who had spoken.

"Isn't that half-Elf with...?"

"Quiet."

"The students say they're outnumbered and the pirates have mages of their own! And their leader is far stronger than the [Captains]—he's already slain two! Where's Archmage Amerys? They need her!"

"She's out hunting!"

The mage turned in desperation.

"One of the other Archmages, then! We need someone who can teleport or fly—if we don't hurry the students will be dead!"

Jurix and Illphres saw the hall devolving into confusion. Some mages—those who could actually teleport—backed away, unwilling to expose themselves to danger. Wistram was full of mages, it was true, but only a fraction of their number was willing to go into combat.

For his part, the Dullahan stared hard at Illphres. She was seated, motionless in her chair. He knew she was thinking.

"Are you going to help?"

"She knew what she was getting into. All those students do. It isn't our job to bail them out."

"Very true. We should let them sort out their own problems. And if they can't, well, that's life."

"Exactly. It's not our problem."

Jurix nodded understandingly. He reached for a plate, and stopped as Illphres stood up. She glared at him.

"Well? Are you coming?"

He grinned and pushed back his chair, already fastening his head securely to his neck.

"I'll message Bastam and Ophelia. We'll get her to teleport us, but it will take several leaps—"

"Hurry. I'll go ahead. I'll be faster."

"Got it."

Illphres strode away from Jurix. She saw heads turning towards her, but paid no attention. Students and mages cried out as ice spread in front of Illphres, but she just stepped forwards.

Her shoes were designed to stick to the ice, but only if she allowed them too. Illphres slid forwards on the ice, gathering momentum as she let the slick ice take her momentum. It spread across the banquet hall, making anyone standing on it slip or be forced to grab a table for support. Calvaron tumbled to the ground with a cry and Beatrice had to grab Mons to keep her upright as Illphres kicked herself across the ice, moving faster.

She shot down the banquet hall, smooth-soled shoes turning as she pivoted, zipping past a group of students. Illphres jumped and cleared the fallen Calvaron. She shot down a corridor and found herself headed at a wall.

Ice rose and curved. Illphres kicked off from one wall and shot up the ramp and onto the far wall. For a few seconds she was horizontal, skating on the far wall, then she dropped down to the ground and kept going, barely losing speed.

She didn't know why she was doing this. Illphres ignored the shouting as her ice magic shot down the hallway, providing her with a passageway to keep skating down, moving faster and faster. There was no reward for this, at least none she cared for. She told herself real mages stood alone.

But she thought of Ceria. She scowled as she shot out Wistram's front doors, blasting them open with a pillar of ice. Illphres felt herself falling, and gazed down at the steps as they came rushing towards her. The steps froze, and the ice turned the hill down towards the docks into a ramp. Illphres sped down it, gathering more speed. She created a ramp for herself at the end and flew out into the ocean, a missile.

Real mages stood alone. But the half-Elf wasn't a real mage yet. And neither was Illphres.

Not yet.

"Get down!"

Ceria screamed as another volley of arrows flew overhead. Half of those who heard her threw themselves down, but the other half were too busy fighting to dodge. She heard screams as several arrows found their mark. One flashed past her head as she held still on the deck of the rocking ship.

As soon as she thought the worst of it was over Ceria was on her feet. She clutched at her arm; she'd been hit once already. The shaft stuck out of

her flesh and Ceria felt faint.

But there was no time to rest or scream. The enemy was everywhere.

The deck of the ship she was on was filled with men and women with swords. Not just any men or women though; the Drowned People. They were a race created when parasites from the ocean fused with Humans or other species. Many were peaceful people, the products of an accident. But others were pirates.

And these were no ordinary raiders, no ragtag group of sea bandits. Someone had gotten their information very wrong, Ceria knew, because eight ships had ambushed the expedition from Wistram at sea. Now they swarmed the three remaining ships, wearing bright red bandanas. That way the archers on the other ships could avoid hitting their friends as they loosed arrows on the mages and mercenaries fighting for their lives.

At least the bandanas made them easy to hit. Ceria raised her hand and pointed three fingers at the nearest pirate.

“*[Ice Dart]!*”

Three shards caught the woman as she turned. Two bounced off the crustacean like shell on her chest, but the third hit her in the throat. She choked but didn’t fall. Ceria saw a mercenary turn and run her through—

“Ceria!”

She felt someone hit her from the side. Ceria fell and saw Pisces. He’d knocked her to the ground just in time to keep her from being run through by a man with a cutlass. He grinned and slashed fast at Pisces.

“*[Flame Jet]!*”

Ceria screamed the spell as she pointed her hands up. The man dodged back from the gout of flame with a curse and gasped as Pisces ran him through. The mage pulled his blade back with a grimace and helped Ceria to her feet.

“We have to run!”

He screamed it in her ears as he pointed to the side. Ceria dragged him back.

“We can’t jump! They’ll kill us in the water easily!”

“In that case—I’ll have to—”

He turned and swore.

“Look out! He’s coming again!”

Ceria turned and saw a ship shooting towards them, black hulled, the front reinforced with steel to create a ram.

The captain of these pirates stood at the head of the deck, grinning, bloody sword in hand. Ceria flinched as she saw him holding two heads. He'd already killed two of the [Captains] of the four ships and sunk one with his vessel. She braced as Pisces gripped the railing—

The impact splintered the hull of the vessel Ceria was standing on and threw her and Pisces apart. She got up groggily, and saw more pirates swinging down onto the deck, charging the outnumbered Wistram students and mercenaries.

Already half of the students had died. The rest fell back, fighting with spells but unable to defend themselves from the brutally efficient blades and arrows that assailed them. Ceria stumbled backwards, firing shards of ice desperately. It wasn't supposed to be like this. They were supposed to be doing the hunting. They could have taken any equal force with their mages, but this—

Fire erupted to one side, burning a group of mercenaries as the pirates cheered. Ceria saw a mage – a man with red robes – standing on one of the far ships. They had mages of their own.

She was going to die here. Ceria backed towards her friends, fellow students, and the mercenaries who'd formed a desperate semicircle on their deck. This was it. The pirate captain led the charge and she fought for her life.

Across the deck, Pisces found himself fighting for his life. He stepped backwards in a flash, parried a blade, and stepped again, thrusting desperately. But his opponent moved as fast as he did, perhaps faster.

"I have a Skill that's a match for your spell, boy."

The man who pushed Pisces backwards was no Drowned Man, but a Human, heavily tattooed on his face and arms. He cut at Pisces, making the mage duck and weave. Pisces muttered under his breath as he took five rapid steps backwards, flashing across the length of the deck.

"Rise, rise unto me—"

He cried out as the man cut his arm with a slash from his offhand. He had a dagger to match with his blade. Now the man stood, sword in one hand, dagger in the other. He beckoned with the dagger at Pisces, challenging.

“I see your bell. Shall we have a duel of it, mage from Wistram?”

Pisces grinned wildly as he cast a spell without words.

“If you want to try, be my guest.”

They spun away, each attempting to catch the other. Pisces leapt from the railing of his ship towards another one. He landed on the deck and the man followed, laughing. The pirates had butchered the crew of this ship and only the dead remained.

“Nowhere to run!”

“No. There isn’t.”

Pisces’ eyes glinted as something moved on the still deck. He brandished his rapier and circled the tattooed man.

Ceria saw Pisces jump, but she could do nothing to help him. She was fighting for her life. It seemed like there was a wall of blades around her. She expected at any moment to be run through, but fought for every second.

Two ships, now. The third was dead in the water, Pisces and the other pirate the only living souls aboard. Ceria saw the other ship approaching, and realized they were coming to help. But more pirate ships were all around, and they were trying to board the other ship. Ceria saw one ship coming dead on, attempting to ram—

“To port! Hard port!”

Someone screamed that. Ceria saw the pirate ship turn, but too slowly. She gaped as a huge blade of ice sudden crashed into the ship, a vertical guillotine that cut the entire vessel in two.

“What was that?”

The attackers stopped their assault as they turned to look. The pirate ship broke in two and began to sink. Ceria turned towards the railing and her heart stopped as she saw a familiar figure, skating across the waves.

Illphres. The ice mage froze the very sea around her as she dashed across the ocean. She moved faster than anything Ceria had ever seen on land, leaving a trail of disintegrating ice as she spun in the air and landed, skating backwards towards another vessel.

From her hands came ice, massive pillars of it that crashed into another pirate ship and broke the wooden hull. Illphres turned, and a wall of ice

formed in front of her as one of the pirate mages blasted her. She raised a finger and hit him in the chest with a spike of ice.

“Mage!”

Ceria heard an incredible roar and turned to see the pirate leader. He was on his ship and it turned incredibly fast towards Illphres. Archers shot at her as she raised a second wall of ice to block them. Calmly, Illphres sent a second scything ice blade to cut apart the pirate leader’s ship.

The ice broke as it struck the hull of the black ship. Ceria, ducking back and throwing fire, saw Illphres pause and heard the captain roar.

“I sailed through storms that have sunk islands, mage! My ship and I are one! I am a [Storm Captain]! Come and fight me if you dare!”

Illphres raced towards him on the frozen sea. She leapt, and a pillar of ice threw her up onto the deck. Ceria cried out. It was a trap! There was no way Illphres could fight an entire crew of pirates and their captain alone. She leapt from the deck of the ship she was on and dove into the waters below.

Pisces remembered the past. With every step and thrust and dodge and parry, he remembered the lessons his father had taught him. His sword felt heavy in his hands, but he dared not stop moving.

“Tiring, mage? You have skill, but I have Skills.”

The tattooed pirate laughed at him as Pisces gasped for air. He was badly winded. Pisces knew he couldn’t continue. He stepped backwards, towards a place where the dead had been cut down in droves. The man advanced, laughing. He was coming for the finishing kill.

One slash nearly tore the rapier Pisces held out of his hands. The thrust with the dagger cut him across the ribs. Pisces hissed, and tripped backwards over a corpse. He raised his rapier as the man stepped over the body—

And it seized him by the leg. The pirate turned, stabbing at the man who rose from the ground.

“What is this?”

He was horrified to find the man who’d grabbed him was dead. The tears in his chest showed clearly where he’d been killed. But he still struck at the pirate, and another zombie grabbed him from the other side.

“Apologies.”

Pisces rose to his feet and lifted his rapier. The tattooed pirate stared at him with horror and fury.

“You coward! This is a duel!”

“Only to you.”

Pisces ran the tattooed man through. He turned, and took a deep breath. More pirates were coming, swinging onto the deck and stopping in horror when they realized who they were facing.

“*Necromancer!*”

“Ah, yes.”

Pisces stared sadly at the dead around him. They charged towards the living and he walked forwards, rapier in hand.

“I suppose there’s no hiding it now.”

Illphres and the [Storm Captain] fought on the deck of his ship, exchanging blows. For Illphres, each spell was a spear of ice, or a storm of frozen daggers that cut down pirate after pirate, merciless, tearing holes in the deck of the ship. But the captain of the pirates dodged each spell, moving with effortless grace and speed on the rocking deck.

And he was strong, too. Each time Illphres raised a wall of ice to block him, he would swing past the wall of ice or shatter it with his enchanted blade. It could pierce her thickest barrier, and she didn’t have the time to fight him and the crew that assailed her from all sides.

He caught her as she froze a score of pirates around her. The captain kicked Illphres off her feet. He tried to stab her through the chest as she lay on the ground, but she pointed and he dropped his sword, howling as it froze his skin.

He drew a dagger from his belt and threw himself at Illphres. She blasted him off his feet with a gust of frozen air, but he was back in a second. He raised his dagger with a yell—

And his foot came down on the patch of slick ice underfoot. Ceria shot an [Ice Dart] at the man’s head as she hauled her drenched body on the deck.

The captain’s boot landed on the ice and he turned and leaned out of the way of the shard of ice. He grinned as Ceria stared at him in dismay.

“On my ship, I cannot be tripped by air, water, or any other thing underfoot, girl.”

Then he turned and leapt out of the way. A flurry of [Ice Spikes] flashed past him, but each one missed. The [Storm Captain] lunged towards Illphres, and cut across her face.

Ceria screamed. But Illphres didn’t fall. Instead, her face fell to pieces. The [Storm Captain] froze as he stared at what remained and Illphres nodded.

“See what the face of a true mage looks like.”

Then the air froze. The deck froze. The captain raised his dagger and—
Froze.

Standing on the other side of the deck, Ceria felt the water on her freeze instantly. She cried out in pain and flailed about, hearing it crack. The cold was *intense*. She saw Illphres, kneeling on the deck.

“Illphres!”

It was minutes before the intense chill faded enough for Ceria to dash over to Illphres. She saw the woman kneeling on the deck, eyes closed, panting heavily. Ceria reached down to her, and froze.

“Yes.”

Illphres looked up, staring at Ceria. Blackened lips moved, but the rest of her face stayed still. Her jaw, her nose—the entire lower half of her face was blackened, the skin dead. Ceria had seen such symptoms before. It was the look of frostbite.

“Do you see?”

Illphres whispered it to Ceria. The shards of ice that had been the—the mask on her face slowly began to melt as the temperature on the ship began to normalize. Ceria could only stare.

“This is what magic looks like.”

“We’re just in time by the looks of it.”

The three mages appeared in the air over the sea. They landed on the choppy water, staggering. Their feet met the surface of the water as if it were solid earth, but the constant movement of the waves still made it hard to stand. One of the mages, a woman with stitching around her hands, gasped for air as the other two caught her.

Jurix, the Dullahan and Bastam, the Drake, turned towards the ships where fighting still continued. Jurix pointed.

“There! Two ships are still active. A third is—”

“Are those zombies?”

Bastam stared intently at one of the ships. Jurix shook his head.

“Look later. I’ll take that ship, Bastam. You take that one.”

“Got it. Go.”

The Dullahan spoke a spell as Bastam began to chant.

“[Whirlwind Leap].”

He shot upwards, propelled by a massive gust of wind that hurled him towards the ship he had chosen. Jurix landed on the deck of one of the enemy ships and began casting spells at once. A trio of pirates rushed at him, but their blades scratched uselessly at his now-impervious armor. The Dullahan struck one with his palm.

“[Tremor Impact].”

The broken body of the Drowned Man flew far over the railing and splashed into the water below. The other pirates backed up, but Jurix pursued them, using [Flash Step] to blink forwards and striking them with the same spell.

Caught by surprise, the pirates tried to swarm the ship Jurix was on. But one of their ships slowed as spells began to rain down from the sky upon it.

[Fireball] and [Lightning Bolt] spells struck the deck of the ship with deadly accuracy. Bastam, standing on the top of the ocean waves with Ophelia, hurled the spells hundreds of meters into the air, arcing them to hit the pirates on deck with deadly accuracy.

Three ships sunk and two more taken by the enemy, the pirates attempted to flee. Illphres sunk one by breaking the hull with [Glacial Spears]—the other two fell to combined attacks from the surviving mages.

And then it was over. Ceria stumbled across the deck of the deceased pirate captain’s ship as Illphres connected it to another ship with a bridge of ice. Ceria wanted to support Illphres; the woman stumbled twice as she walked, but the woman just shrugged her hands off.

“Leave me. Find your friend.”

Ceria hesitated, but then ran onto the other ship. She called out for Pisces, searching for him among the surviving mercenaries and student mages. Then she remembered he’d gone to the other ship.

“*Pisces!*”

The ship was full of people. How? Ceria shouted as the last surviving [Captain] turned his ship alongside the vessel. For a moment she thought one of the other ships had sent people to help Pisces fight, but then someone standing next to her cried out in horror.

“Zombies!”

They stood motionless on the deck, swaying slightly as the ship rocked back and forth. The undead. Some were mercenaries, others, Wistram students. More still were pirates, brought back from the dead after being slain. The ship was full of death.

And one living person. Pisces stood at the railing, a bloody rapier in hand. He was cut badly, but intact. He stared across the railing and then stared at the mercenaries and other mages. They all gazed at him, some vomiting, others backing away in fear.

Someone dropped a gangplank. Ceria saw Pisces step up. He walked across to her ship, and stopped in front of her. She just stared at him, not fully understanding. Not wanting to understand.

Pisces couldn't meet her eyes. He cleared his throat, stared at the ground. He looked at Ceria at last, and there was guilt in his eyes.

“I wanted to tell you—”

Ceria took a step back. The corpses standing on the deck stared vacantly ahead. The head of one had been hacked nearly apart, but it stood, bits of gore and brain falling to the rocking deck. Illphres regarded Pisces silently as both sailors and the other students stared at him in horror.

But he only had eyes for Ceria. Pisces lowered his crimson rapier.

“Ceria—”

She backed away from him. Ceria felt weak. Her head was spinning. She took one more look at the undead that Pisces—her friend had created and threw up.

“Necromancer.”

It was the word on the tongues of every student and mage in Wistram. Even the dramatic battle at sea paled in comparison to the attention, anger, and hatred focused around one person.

Pisces. He stood in front of the Council, the assembly of mages presided over by the Archmages of Wistram, the body that governed the academy.

Normally the Council voted on topics such as policy, Wistram's stance towards nations, appointing new teachers, but it also served a rarely-fulfilled role as arbiter.

Standing on a balcony in the huge, circular room, Ceria stood next to Calvaron and Montressa as she stared down at Pisces, standing alone as he faced the Council. Beatrice had refused to attend the hearing. Or was it a trial? It felt like one.

The accusation was simple. Pisces was a [Necromancer]. It wasn't as if Wistram had outlawed that school of magic explicitly—and yet, it was clear that they had. No sane mage practiced necromancy. It violated the dead. It was a tool used by crazed cults and madmen to create armies to assail the living.

It was wrong.

And yet Pisces stood in front of the Council and argued. Ceria heard his voice ringing through the chamber, confident, beseeching the other mages to understand. She stared at Montressa and saw the girl's horrified face, and the grim look on Calvaron's.

"Magic is pure! Necromancy is a force to be wielded for good or evil, not inherently biased in itself! And is Wistram not a place where all mages may study? Consider, I implore you, the case of Az'kerash! His name is infamous as the most powerful [Necromancer] of this millennium. He once studied here before he was slain on Izril. His sins are legion, that is undeniable—and yet, is he not an example to study and admire?"

Outrage. The rumble of voices in the room rose, but Pisces spoke over them.

"Yes, admire! I came here to follow in his footsteps, to see if anyone else understood necromancy as he did, or if he left anything behind. Az'kerash was evil, it is true, but he was also a master of magic! He gazed deeper into the heart of magic than any but the greatest [Archmages] before him. Is this not something we should accept? Necromancy is the equal of any other magical school!"

Mages sitting or standing around the room shouted at this, furiously denouncing Pisces. But he ignored them. His eyes were only for the Council. He spread his arms pleadingly.

"Wistram Academy is a place where the study of magic comes before all else. Before law, before morality or ethical concern. Here, magic is all. I came to study magic, to deepen my understanding of it. Wistram once held

a single phrase to be true: ‘To ever strive’. I ask that you allow me to study, to be part of this institution and add to it as the one expert in my field. I have committed no crimes, despoiled no graves. I simply wish to learn.”

They debated. And argued. A few stood for Pisces. Amerys was one of them. But slowly, Ceria saw the Council and the opinion of the mages swing only one way. At the end of it, a man stood. He was old, one of the Archmages, and the only one besides Amerys that Ceria knew.

The half-Elf, the ancient mage who had represented Wistram for over a century. Archmage Feor. He stared down at Pisces and spoke quietly.

“Wistram will turn away no mage who seeks to learn and is worthy of it. But necromancy is not taught within these halls. It is not accepted. And if you choose to study here, Pisces, you will do so alone. We hereby revoke your scholarship. If you would stay, pay the full dues owed to the academy. Otherwise, you must leave. That is the decision of the Council.”

Pisces walked alone after that. He walked through hallways and rooms, but found no one who would speak with him. Some spat, others cursed him.

And when he found his friends, one would not stop to speak with him. Beatrice left. Montressa, Ceria, and Calvaron stayed, but all three looked at him as if he were different. Changed.

Evil.

“I have...one day to come up with the funds to pay Wistram. Or I must leave.”

Pisces’ voice shook with rage, pain, and anguish. Ceria wanted to hug him, but she couldn’t bring herself to. He was a [Necromancer]. He raised the dead.

It all added up. Already students were putting clues together. Someone had raided Pisces’ room, found the small army of undead mice he used to spy with. They had been burned, as had almost all of Pisces’ possessions.

“Do you have enough coin to pay? I know you had a lot saved up—”

Calvaron looked at Pisces with a trace of sympathy. Pisces shook his head roughly.

“Not—not enough. I need more, and a lot of it.”

“Well, I—I’m afraid I can’t lend it to you, Pisces. I could trade you secrets—and I’ll give you a good price for them—but I don’t think you

have enough of those either.”

Calvaron didn’t meet Pisces’ gaze. Ceria didn’t look at him either. Montressa just stared at Pisces, as if she wasn’t sure who she was seeing.

“I know. I’ll trade you what I have. But I need more coin. So—this.”

Pisces fumbled for something at his side. Ceria saw him lift his rapier up. Calvaron froze as Pisces offered it to him.

“Would this be enough? If you sold it—it is worth a large sum to the right buyers. Is it enough?”

The rapier trembled in his hands, and the silver bell chimed once. Ceria stared at Pisces. Calvaron was silent for a long time before he replied.

“Enough to pay the academy’s fees? I can probably do that. But—are you sure?”

“I am.”

Pisces jerked his head. It could have been a nod. Calvaron stared at him, and then took the blade. Pisces stared at it, face white, and turned away. He stumbled as he walked out of the banquet hall.

No one went after him.

It was quiet when Ceria found Illphres. Somehow, the spirit of Wistram had been sucked out, or so she felt. Everything felt hollow, and empty. Even when she saw people laughing, it sounded fake and insincere.

The ice mage opened her door when Ceria called out. She admitted Ceria into her room and for the first time, Ceria saw the inside.

It was just a room. Cold, far colder than normal, but there was a bed and a bookshelf, and precious little else. Illphres only had time for magic.

The ice mage sat at a table with Ceria as the half-Elf shivered. Ceria couldn’t help but stare at Illphres’ mouth. The ice mage had restored her mask of ice, and her flesh looked healthy and normal. But now Ceria knew.

“You see, it’s why I have to alter my face to smile.”

Illphres showed Ceria, warping the ice around her face to change her expressions. The ice rippled and shifted unnaturally as Ceria watched, making her feel queasy.

“Far easier to hide it.”

The woman passed a hand over her lips and smiled bitterly. Ceria stared at her.

“Thank you for saving me.”

This was the first chance she’d had to say it. Illphres waved a hand over her face and changed it back to impassiveness.

“I suppose the fault is mine. I’m too soft-hearted.”

That made Ceria laugh. But that flash of humor was swallowed up by the hole in her heart. Illphres studied her.

“Your friend has upset the other mages. If he stays, he will only face their hostility. He will not be accepted here, not ever.”

“I know.”

“Did you know he was a [Necromancer]?”

“No!”

Ceria shuddered.

“If I had known—I think he wanted to tell me. But if I had known—!”

“You would have done what, stopped him? It is magic. He is a mage.”

“You think it’s okay?”

Ceria stared at Illphres in horror. She could still see the lifeless eyes of the dead people Pisces had brought back. Dead, and yet moving. Far worse than a golem; someone who had been alive once, forced to shamble about. Illphres just shrugged.

“It is magic. In his own way, your friend Pisces aspires to be what I yearn to be as well. A true mage. And you want the same thing, unless I am mistaken.”

“I do. But Pisces—I’m not the same as him.”

“He is a mage. And you are a mage. And I...I am a mage. But none of us are true mages. Not yet. I lost to that pirate captain. If you hadn’t bought me time to cast that spell, I would have died.”

Illphres said it matter-of-factly. Ceria nodded.

“But you saved me. You did what I never could. You’re a better mage than I am.”

“Yes. I am.”

The two sat in silence for a while. At last, Ceria asked the question, knowing the answer.

“Will you teach me magic?”

Illphres paused.

“Yes. If you truly wish it.”

It was the answer Ceria had been waiting half a year to hear. But it filled her with nothing. She looked down at her hands.

“Is it really okay? Is Pisces really...”

“The mages here would say one thing. I say another. Follow me and become a true mage. Then you will know the answer.”

Illphres held out a hand and Ceria stared at it. She looked at the woman, the mage, who hid her pain behind a mask of ice. She thought of her friend, who had hid behind lies. The person she barely knew. She saw what magic looked like, what it truly looked like.

Slowly, Ceria reached out and took Illphres' hand.

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Wistram Days (Pt.6)

On a controversial report published by one of the foremost [Emissaries], Trixal Therest in the year 2 EL.R, he listed Wistram as one of the most powerful factions in the world. Trixal's report was issued to one of the Great Companies of Baleros who had hired him to write the primer, but it soon became widely disseminated across the world.

Other [Historians], [Diplomats], and other notable cosmopolitans soon voiced their outrage over Trixal's report, which was claimed to be inaccurate and grossly misleading not to mention biased. However, while many charges were leveled at the characterization of other world powers, no words were spoken against Wistram's position. For Wistram was an undisputed world power, if an often quiet one.

Mages. They worked for lots of gold and sometimes caused trouble, but they were indispensable. Of course, any organization that trained young spellcasters could be a threat, and other nations competed with each other to create their own institutions of magic now and then. But Wistram was safe from such politics, or indeed most wars due to its famed neutrality.

If the mages of Wistram did take part in a war, it was by declining to provide services, boycotting specific groups or countries, and so on. Few times in recorded history did mages fight on battlefields against a specific kingdom or empire. When mages did take to the field in numbers, it was against common enemies such as the Demonfolk of Rhir, or against a Goblin King or similar calamity.

Still, were it not for the benefits Wistram provided to all, it surely would have been taken over by one nation or other over the countless years it had existed. Wistram occupied a central point for all ships crossing the ocean, providing them with a place to trade, sell, and resupply. Yet few armies had ever taken Wistram by force, and none had ever breached the gates since the Golems of Archmage Zelkyr had been created to protect the isle.

But what kept Wistram alive? Trade was only a part of the mage's economy, and that by itself would not allow mages to live in such splendor. No, it was

the unparalleled quality of their education. A mage may be made of any fool with a basic grasp of magic, but of Wistram mages, it was said that the weakest of them was a match for any Silver-rank adventurer.

And that was broadly correct. A mage passed by Wistram was almost always a studied graduate of at least six years, capable of casting many spells and studied in a wide variety of fields. She or he or they owed it all to the rigorous training given to them by their teachers, older mages who imparted their knowledge to the new students.

That was the true value of Wistram. Its teachers. Each one defined the experience the students would go through year to year, and so it was small wonder the students quickly learned which teachers could be appeased, which ones were competent and which were barely able to convey their subject matter and of course, which ones were to be feared.

The teacher for basic combat magic this year was not happy. Few teachers saddled with the job were. Teaching magic to the newest students, those that had passed their entrance exams, was not an easy job, and the salary provided by the council was meager. It was a task mages fought to avoid.

Perhaps that was why this mage was angry. Then again, it could have just been her personality. All the new students knew was that their teacher was as terrifying as she was good at ice magic. And whenever they saw her in the hallways, or now, entering the banquet hall for breakfast, they took care to greet her deferentially while clearing a path.

“Good morning, professor.”

“Hello, professor.”

It was a title of respect. And fear. The students backed away from their magic teacher, letting her select her food and pile it onto a plate before moving away to their collective relief. The teacher stalked away towards a far table, face frozen with a hostility that her students had grown to dread.

“Hoi, teacher! Over here!”

Someone waved to her. The mage turned. Her face changed little, but she scowled as she sat down with a few other mages for breakfast. One of them grinned at her.

“Hi there. How’s it going, professor Ceria?”

Calvaron stared at Ceria Springwalker’s glaring face for a few more seconds and then burst out laughing. He howled with mirth as he pounded the table Beatrice and Mons sat at. Ceria kept glaring until the Centaur had finished.

“You done? Because if you’re not, I’ll shove an icicle so far up your—”

“Whoa there, don’t take it out on me! Please, professor, show mercy!”

The Centaur raised his hands in mock fright. He grinned at Ceria, still sniggering at her. She wanted to throw her plate at him, but it wouldn’t be worth it. Calvaron had been laughing about the title her students had given her since the year had started. She growled as she cut into the steak slathered with butter on her plate.

“I keep telling them *not* to call me that.”

“Yes, but you know students. They have to have a nickname for their teachers, and I think ‘professor’ suits you quite well. Don’t you, Beatrice?”

The Dullahan looked up from her plate and nodded her head with her hands. She had a book open by her head and was alternating between staring at that and nibbling on cheese.

“It’s a better name than Scaleslough. That’s what they called our old teacher.”

“Dead gods, I’d forgotten! We used to call old Tshya that all the time! That brings back memories.”

The Centaur smiled at the memory, but Beatrice did not. She looked at Ceria.

“How are classes going?”

“How do you expect? Badly.”

Ceria made a face as she forked a dripping piece of meat into her mouth. She wanted to grimace, but the hot meat made her too happy to properly grouch. Instead, she only sighed, sipping at the sweet juice in her cup as she stretched out on the comfy cushioned seats she’d grown used to.

“All these new students don’t know the difference between a fire spell and a water one, I swear. Their magical composition is terrible, they can’t compress their mana correctly, their aim is so bad I have to put up a ward or they’ll hit each other—”

The half-Elf broke off, affronted as Calvaron *and* Beatrice laughed at this. Mons had to smile too, although she tried to look away from Ceria. Ceria growled as she eyed her friends.

“What’s so funny?”

“Sorry, Ceria. It’s just that—every teacher always says the same thing about their students.”

Calvaron chuckled as he explained.

“All the mages who have to teach say it. And all of the older students say it too. Why, not two years ago I heard all the older mages saying it about your year.”

“They did not.”

Beatrice nodded, smiling.

“Did too. And now you’re saying it. It’s funny.”

Ceria turned her head to stare at Montressa. The younger girl turned red, but she grinned sheepishly at Ceria.

“Calvaron and Beatrice said you’d complain, Ceria. But it’s a good thing you do, isn’t it? It means you care about your students.”

“Well...I’m their teacher. I have to care.”

Ceria hunched her shoulders defensively. Calvaron wagged his finger at her.

“Ah, ah. Don’t be modest, Ceria. I hear good things about your class. You may torture your students—”

“I do *not*—”

“—torture them with lessons harder than all the rest of their classes combined, but they’re learning a lot from you. The students can tell, for all

they think you're the scariest half-Elf they've ever met. You're doing a good job."

"Well."

Ceria couldn't think of anything to say in reply. She tried not to blush, but knew her ears had turned slightly red.

"It's just a job. I didn't want it. It's a pain and it's keeping me from studying—anyways, it's fine. What about you three? I've been so busy I haven't had time to catch up with you all this year."

The other students sitting at Ceria's table shrugged. She eyed Calvaron and Beatrice, largely unchanged since she'd gotten to know them. The only real difference was that Calvaron was a bit heavier, having gained weight, and Beatrice had upgraded her plain metal armor with a new coat of paint and what looked like steel mixed in with the common iron.

They had grown. But so had Mons, and in far more dramatic ways than the other two. In the year after the infamous day when Ceria had been caught up in a battle at sea with a powerful pirate navy, the young girl had turned into a young woman.

Humans grew up so fast. In one year, Mons had finished most of her adolescence and become, well, as physically old as Ceria. She had grown two inches taller, and her hair had gotten longer. Her breasts were a bit bigger, she had a bit more muscle, and she was more confident than the girl Ceria had met.

Now Mons smiled at Ceria, the depths of her pale saffron-topaz irises glinting in the morning light. She looked rather strange to Ceria, with her red hair and bright eyes. Half-Elves didn't have naturally red hair. Staring at her now, the half-Elf felt a pang in her chest. In one year, Ceria had barely changed, but Mons had transformed. How much different would she become by the time Ceria graduated?

"And you, Mons? How are classes in the second year?"

"Good! I'm really enjoying my classes on ward spells. I don't know why, but I've got a real knack for casting them. I've gotten a Skill – [Layered Ward]! I think I could really specialize in that field!"

“That’s great news, Mons.”

Ceria smiled at the young woman while Calvaron and Beatrice made similar complimentary noises.

“You never told me you got a Skill, Mons! When was this?”

“Last week. And I told Beatrice, but I didn’t tell you because she said you’d just sell the secret to someone.”

Mons’ eyes twinkled as Calvaron spluttered and turned red. Ceria laughed.

“Well, I’m glad you’ve learned how to put Calvaron in his place. I thought you’d be in real trouble with me gone.”

“It’s not been the same without you, Ceria.”

Calvaron sighed and shook his head.

“Mons and Beatrice try, but no one has your sharp tongue—or penchant for kicking and throwing things at people. I keep telling them, only you can kick like a real Centaur.”

“Shut up.”

“No, I’m serious. Ever since you went off and had to become Illphres’ apprentice, things have been so lonely. How could you just abandon us like that?”

“You’re disgusting. Didn’t you win a bundle for betting I’d be able to do it when everyone said I didn’t have a chance?”

“Of course. But that’s that and this is this.”

Calvaron smiled smugly, causing Ceria to flick her fingers and spray a cloud of snow in his face. He yelped as the freezing snowflakes melted on his fur.

“Aah! That’s the Ceria I know and love!”

She had to laugh at that. Ceria eyed Calvaron as she finished her food. He really hadn’t changed much. And yet, she knew he had taken his own steps towards becoming a mage over the year.

“How’s your own work going, Calvaron? You’re in your sixth year, now. One more and you’ll be able to call yourself a mage. Excited?”

“Hah. Terrified is more like. I’m practicing my tail off for the exam, but really, I’m more worried about collecting secrets and coin right now.”

Calvaron flicked his fingers, making the water on his face and arms vanish in a puff.

“Being a mage means I’ll really get embroiled in faction politics. I want the coin and secrets to, well, keep doing as I’ve done. I figure that without classes, I’ll be able to establish myself as a really influential broker between all the sides in Wistram.”

“Or you could take one and keep studying instead.”

Beatrice turned her head to frown at Calvaron. He avoided her gaze and Ceria sighed. She knew he and Beatrice had been fighting about his future. Calvaron was content to earn a living and continue being the affable Centaur everyone went to when they wanted to sell or buy things, but Beatrice wanted him to join her faction, the Revivalists.

It was an argument Ceria wanted no part of, so she sat back as Calvaron cleared his throat awkwardly.

“I’m...not interested in their goals, you know that, Beatrice. I support some of their agendas, but other things they say—I can’t. Anyways, I need to be neutral. You know that.”

She said nothing, just narrowed her eyes. To break the tension, Mons turned brightly to Ceria.

“So, um, Ceria. How are things between you and Pisces? Have you seen him around?”

The mood at the table—froze. Beatrice turned the head in her hands to stare at Mons and the girl flinched. Calvaron covered his face with his hand and Ceria stopped eating.

“I haven’t seen him around recently.”

“Neither have I. I suppose he’s studying quite a lot. But you know, that’s how it is. We’re so busy studying—Ceria, how are lessons with Illphres going? Does she expect as much from you as you do from your students?”

Mons ignored Calvaron’s desperate attempt to shift the conversation. She stared at Ceria.

“I spoke with him the other day. He was teaching me about how to use the [Flame Arrow] spell more effectively.”

“Oh?”

Ceria looked at Mons, surprised.

“You still...keep in touch with him?”

“I see him at least once or twice a week. He’s busy—studying—a lot, but he could use some visitors. I think it might be good if you talked with him.”

Mons met Ceria’s eyes squarely. The half-Elf didn’t know what to say. Across the table, Calvaron fiddled with his fork and Beatrice turned her head back to her spellbook without a word.

“I’ll—think about it.”

That was all Ceria could come up with. Mons nodded, and the table fell into a deep silence.

Even after a year, there was one word, one name that couldn’t be spoken aloud.

Pisces.

Ceria closed her eyes and pushed her plate back a bit, no longer hungry anymore. Even now, after so many months—

It still hurt. It still made her stomach churn.

Pisces was a [Necromancer].

The entire academy knew about it, now. The new students learned this fact within days of arriving. There was a necromancer studying among them. A twisted, deranged madman who experimented with the dead.

What could be more abhorrent? What could be more wrong? Necromancers had existed since the dawn of magic, but today they were shunned and feared. Famous examples among their kind had been used to haunt children's dreams for generations, and the tale of Az'kerash, the horror that had brought death to two continents for over a century before being slain, still lurked in everyone's memory.

Necromancy was evil. Few species could look into the rotting, dead eyes of a corpse and see anything but wrongness there. Perhaps the Selphid students sympathized with Pisces, and maybe there were those who quietly thought he did nothing wrong. But they were silent and the rest of the academy turned their backs on him.

Including Beatrice. The first time he had come to sit with them after his trial she'd nearly attacked him herself. Calvaron had—he hadn't attacked Pisces, but neither could he look the young man in the eye. Ceria couldn't either. Only Mons had stayed by Pisces' side.

"Do that."

The young woman nodded to Ceria, looking around the table seriously. She still trusted Pisces, still talked with him. Ceria could understand—but not condone.

He raised the dead. If she came to grips with that, he had still lied to her about who he was. She'd known him for over a year and he'd lied to her.

"Well, I think I'm ready for an after-breakfast dessert. Anyone want something?"

Calvaron heaved himself up and Beatrice caught at his arm.

"You'll get fatter. Don't eat."

"*Beatrice—*"

"Actually, before you go Calvaron, I did have some business to discuss with you."

Ceria interrupted the upcoming squabble. She saw Calvaron brighten as he looked at her and saw Beatrice's smile of gratitude. Ceria tilted her head slightly as Calvaron sank back down.

“I’m always willing to help a friend out! What did you need, Ceria?”

“A ring or amulet with enchantments that resist ice and cold temperatures. I need good stuff, Calvaron. Not a shoddy spell, but one with the best binding available—something I could use if I had other enchanted items on me.”

Calvaron’s eyebrows raised.

“You need cold resistant magic? What, Illphres is too chilly for you?”

Ceria scowled at him.

“I need what I need, Calvaron. The question is, can *you* get it for me?”

He looked affronted.

“Of course I can! But it’ll be very expensive, you know that Ceria.”

“Price is no object. The highest-grade enchantments you can get, Calvaron, so long as they have no magical leakage. And I’ll need two of them.”

“Two? What for?”

Calvaron was alight with curiosity, but Ceria clamped her lips shut. She wagged a finger at him.

“Ask me no questions and I...won’t freeze your face off.”

“Ooh. I’m so tempted but—very well. I’ll ask around. You’re sure two? And you’re good for—alright, alright, I trust you! Talk to me in a week or two and I’ll let you know what I find. Okay?”

“Thanks, Calvaron.”

Ceria smiled and stood up. Beatrice looked surprised.

“Going so soon?”

“I’ve got to. Sorry. Illphres doesn’t have that much time and I have classes to prepare for—you know how it is.”

“Well then, stop by another time Ceria. You know where to find us!”

“Will do. See you Calvaron, Mons. Beatrice.”

Ceria waved and walked away. She levitated her plates into a wicker bin designed to hold them—a new addition to the banquet hall after the [Chefs] complained they were running out of dishes since students would pile them up ten feet into the air rather than send them into the kitchen—and walked out of the banquet hall.

By now, Ceria knew most of the academy back to front. The only places she hadn't gone were the highest levels and deep into the bowels of the academy. It was still dangerous to wander in those places incautiously, but Ceria knew all the best shortcuts everywhere else.

So in less than five minutes, she was standing outside a door from which cold emanated. Ceria rapped on the frozen surface, ignoring the chill that made other students and mages hurry past her. She'd long since learned several spells to help with the cold.

After a moment, the door opened. A woman walked out. She nodded to Ceria—Ceria nodded back.

“You have eaten?”

“Just now. Do you want to have breakfast first or—?”

“Let's go.”

Illphres walked down the corridor slowly. Ceria followed. Her relationship with her master, Illphres, was a simple one. Illphres ordered and Ceria usually obeyed. They didn't waste time with greetings or chitchat, mainly because Illphres had no tolerance for it.

“Hey master.”

“Don't call me that.”

Illphres turned and scowled at Ceria. The half-Elf took the glare unfazed.

“I get called ‘Professor Springwalker’ because of you. If I get called names, so do you.”

Illphres paused. She moved her hand past her mouth, and when she lowered it, she was smiling.

“They call you that? Hah.”

“It’s your fault.”

Ceria scowled as the woman turned and kept walking slowly down the corridors. Illphres just shrugged.

“So?”

“Most masters don’t make their apprentices teach their classes for them.”

“They should. It’s convenient.”

Ceria glowered. That was the thing about Illphres. She didn’t care at all about your feelings, and in fact seemed to delight in annoying other people.

And she usually came up with inventive ways to do it. Not that she’d deliberately gotten herself a teaching position for another year on purpose—that was just politics. But it had definitely been Illphres’ idea to make Ceria do the teaching instead.

Most masters made their apprentices get them food, or clean their rooms, organize their notes, assist with spellcasting and so on. But Illphres hated for anyone to do any of that for her—she wouldn’t let Ceria pull her seat out for her. And yet, she had no problems ordering Ceria to spend half her day teaching and preparing her next lesson for students when it suited her.

“I’ve barely had time to practice with all my lessons, you know.”

“But you *do* practice, don’t you?”

“Of course!”

“Hmm. We’ll see.”

Illphres led Ceria to a well-used set of rooms, looking at glowing stones on the doors until she found one that wasn’t lit.

“In here.”

They entered into the practice room. It was just an empty room, really. Some had furniture or other objects that could be used for magic practice, but most were just empty. This one had a white marble floor—enchanted of course, to protect against the spells mages would test in here.

Illphres paused in the center of the room and turned to face Ceria.

“Now, attack me.”

There was no warm up, no preamble. Ceria just raised her finger and started casting magic.

“[Ice Dart]! [Ice Spike]! [Frost Arrows]!”

The spells shot from her fingers in the form of deadly shards of ice, some as long as Ceria’s forearm and twice as wide. They shattered harmlessly on the sheets of thick ice that had materialized in front of Illphres. The woman let the slabs of ice hover around her, creating a multi-layered shield Ceria strove to break.

Her [Ice Dart] spell did little to the thick ice, for all it was a rain of projectiles. Ceria’s newly learned [Ice Spike] spell created a few cracks, but the heavier shots didn’t do much. And her final spell, a storm of fourteen arrows that shattered against the ice barrier and left Ceria gasping for air—did nothing.

“All done?”

“Yeah.”

Ceria gasped for air and wiped at her brow, despite the chill in the air. Illphres let the icy barrier around her dissipate, the ice melting into water which vanished, and nodded.

“Not bad. If you ignore the fact that you’d be dead if any of your opponents knew magic of their own or had a bow.”

That stung. Ceria looked up, glowering at Illphres.

“Most students my year can’t cast a Tier 3 spell half as many times as I can! My offense is fine—”

“But your defense is terrible. Why didn’t you raise [Barrier of the Winds] before casting?”

“I don’t know it yet. You’re the one who told me to focus on ice magic! Why don’t you teach me [Frozen Shield] instead?”

Illphres' face didn't change, but the tone of her voice was definitely a sneer.

"Bah. [Frozen Shield] is a terrible spell. Just buy a real shield if you want to block something. You'll be better off learning [Wall of Ice] when you're at a higher level."

The two mages continued to argue as Ceria and Illphres took a position facing the far wall. Illphres made colored targets of ice appear and Ceria hit them, Illphres correcting her as they bickered.

"Don't I get a say in what I learn?"

"Of course not. You're an idiot whereas I know what spells are best. Your [Ice Spike] spell is flawed—see there? Correct it."

Ceria gritted her teeth as she did.

"Why won't you teach me more advanced spells? I want to learn more, not keep practicing one spell over and over!"

"Mastery of the [Ice Spike] spell is key to learning the [Glacial Spear] spell. Besides, you don't need variety—you need to perfect the basics first."

Ceria grumbled under her breath and her ears drooped, but she finished practicing without any more complaints. Illphres was an excellent teacher even if she taught in much the same style as her element. Slowly, exactly, choosing to perfect every spell before moving on to the next one. Still, Ceria couldn't complain. She had an excellent teacher. Although she sometimes wondered...

As Illphres was walking towards the door without a word of goodbye, Ceria called out.

"Master."

"Call me that again and I'll freeze your toes off."

Illphres turned, her face a scowl. Ceria shrugged insolently.

"...Master, *why* do you need two enchanted items to protect against the cold? I know it's not for me."

The ice mage scowled deeper, reshaping the ice mask on her face to do so.

“Of course it’s not for *you*. If you couldn’t handle my cold spells by now I’d have gotten rid of you already.”

“Then who *is* it for? I talked to Calvaron, but he says it’ll be a week or two before he can find anything.”

Illphres hesitated. Ceria waited, hoping she would get an actual reply. Illphres’ eyes pierced her apprentice, and she seemed to come to a conclusion.

“Maybe you’re ready. But—”

She glanced around the empty room meaningfully. There was no one to listen in, but Ceria knew that an eavesdropping spell might not be detectable even if they cast [Detect Magic].

“I will tell you later.”

Ceria nodded and asked no more. She felt happy Illphres was willing to confide in her. Usually the woman just gave her orders and suffered no question. But perhaps she was trusting Ceria more? They’d been master and apprentice for over half a year now, and Ceria felt like she knew Illphres almost as well as anyone in the academy.

Drained from her practice session with the woman, Ceria exited the practice room, walking slowly down the hallways. She did not walk back towards Illphres’ room where she now had her own quarters. Instead, Ceria took a familiar route, one she hadn’t used in a long time. She walked down to the first level, and soon found herself standing next to a familiar door.

Pisces still lived in the same room he had when they were first-year students. He had no master. Ceria knew the room she had used to live in—and indeed, most of the rooms around his—were empty.

She stared for a long time at the door. Thinking. At last, she raised her hand to knock. Ceria hesitated.

Then she turned and walked slowly away.

Ceria had no intention of talking to Pisces. It wasn't that she couldn't handle the meeting, it was just that she didn't want to speak with him. But fate conspired against her, or perhaps it was the finite amount of space even in a place as large as Wistram.

About a month later, Ceria found a knot of students and raised voices that was the sure sign of a duel, either magical or verbal, going on in one of the hallways. Pushing her way into the group, Ceria saw the duel was of the latter kind, and going on between a fourth-year student and—

Pisces.

Ceria's heart skipped a beat when she saw him. Pisces was standing across from his opponent in a ring of bodies, speaking loudly. He had changed much since she'd seen him last.

Gone were Pisces' rapier and the silver bell. It now belonged to Timor du Havrington, Ceria knew. And gone was Pisces' smile, and indeed his normally semi-neat appearance.

Now his robes were dirty, a sign that he had little time or inclination to clean. They looked slept in, and ragged. Pisces had no coin to buy new ones. Ceria listened as the other student, a loudly-speaking cross between a dog and man—one of the Beastkin—concluded his point.

“—and so your foul practice drags down the status of mages everywhere. No nation respects a [Necromancer], and thus, why should Wistram? Why should we condone a school of magic condemned by the entire world?”

A murmur of agreement ran through the students listening to the debate. Ceria saw Pisces draw himself up. His posture was different. He hunched his shoulders more, and glared at his opponent as he sniffed and launched his counter argument.

“Necromancers have no place in the world? Who decides such things? Popular opinion? If that is the case, I must inquire, what of Archmage Nekhret? Was she undeserving of her title despite being tainted, as you seem to insinuate, by the foul practice of necromancy? She was a true [Archmage], not some pretender to the class! She represented the soul of

Wistram over a thousand years ago—her bones still lie in the catacombs below the academy itself!”

“She lived over a thousand years ago!”

“Age is immaterial! My point is that she was an Archmage, someone who represented Wistram. Should she be condemned? No—more broadly speaking, can any group of mages be condemned for the actions of a few? I put to you, what about the actions of the infamous Burning Killer, Calico, who was just caught and executed in Chandrar? Do his actions define mages as a whole? Should we look askance at every [Pyromancer] because of him? Let me ask to you this question—”

As she watched, Ceria knew Pisces would lose. His arguments were sound, but he had lost his audience, probably before the debate had begun. When they voted, the group of students chosen to listen to the debate all voted unanimously. Pisces had lost, and so the winner collected his spoils—a small bag that might have had coin or something else—and walked away without another word.

The students dispersed, leaving Pisces to stare murderously at the ground. Ceria approached half-unwillingly. She hesitated before she spoke, but she did speak.

“I hope you didn’t bet anything valuable on that debate.”

Pisces’ head jerked up. He stared at Ceria in disbelief.

“Ceria?”

She met his gaze levelly. The shock faded and Pisces’ expression returned to normal. Now it was a bitter scowl and a sardonic crook of the mouth that was supposed to be a smile. He turned away from her, brushing at his robes.

“Ah, you mean the debate? I wagered nothing of consequence, I assure you. I am...used to the bias of the masses even when presented with the most rational of arguments.”

“So I see. Why bother debating at all, then?”

He glanced back at her haughtily.

“I suppose it is to prove that I have a voice, and perhaps to sway opinions. They are bound under a truth spell to vote for whomever presents the best case, you know.”

“But they hate necromancy.”

“Not all! I have had a few vote in my favor—”

Pisces paused. He sniffed again, and frowned at Ceria.

“Not that it matters. Why, pray tell, have you sought me out?”

“I didn’t. I was just walking and saw a debate was going on.”

“I see.”

The two stared at each other. Ceria shifted from foot to foot as Pisces stared over her shoulder. It was...so hard to see him like this. At last, Ceria sighed.

“I talked to Mons a while ago. She says she studies with you.”

“Mons? Ah—she does. She hires me on occasion to provide her with instruction.”

“That’s good. For you, I mean.”

“Yes, it does...help.”

More silence. After a moment, Pisces cleared his throat.

“You know, I am studying combat magic in my spare time.”

“Really? I thought you gave up dueling.”

“Ah, yes, well, I cannot seem to find a match. I have no desire to duel practiced mages and I seem to be boycotted by all other students—but I am attempting to refine what spells I know. Mons claims to have benefitted greatly from practicing with me.”

Ceria tried to smile, but all she did was lift the corners of her mouth.

“That’s great, Pisces.”

“Indeed. You are—you would be welcome to join us if you had the time. I realize you may be somewhat preoccupied with your classes, but...”

Part of her wanted to say yes, but she couldn't. Slowly, Ceria shook her head.

"I don't think we're friends anymore, Pisces."

He looked her in the eyes then. She saw hurt and pain in his, but Pisces didn't say what was clearly on the tip of his tongue. He was about to, but bit back the words. Then his eyes focused on Ceria's again.

"In that case, are we enemies?"

He stared at her, searching for something, eyes gaunt and bloodshot, his robes dirty. Ceria felt a pang in her heart and glared at him.

"Don't be stupid."

She whirled and walked angrily away. But Ceria knew Pisces was smiling, just a tiny bit, behind her. She murmured under her breath.

"We couldn't be enemies."

Four days later, Ceria found herself sitting at a table with Illphres and four other mages. She was nervous, terrified out of her mind, and nearly knocked over her drink twice when she reached for it.

Illphres glared at her.

"Stop fidgeting."

"I don't see how she could, with you glaring at her so, Illphres."

A tall Dullahan seated next to Ceria said that. His name was Jurix, and he was a powerful mage specializing in combat magic and physical reinforcement magic. Sitting across from Ceria, a Drake named Bastam winked at her reassuringly. Ophelia, the Stitch-woman, smiled at Ceria, and the last mage, another Dullahan named Qum, nodded impassively at her.

That made Ceria feel a bit better, but she was still on pins and needles in the presence of so many important mages. She was sitting in the banquet hall, but at one of the tables usually claimed by older mages. It was made of some kind of expensive wood and the chairs were clearly expensive, if a bit worn, but Ceria would have preferred cushions.

And yet, it suited these mages well, because these five were all individuals who commanded quite a bit of influence and power of their own within Wistram. Each one was old; Ophelia, the youngest, was in her early thirties and Bastam, the oldest, was in his sixties, although he didn't look it.

Any one of them—including Illphres—could cause an upset if they threw their influence into a political fight. Three of them were Isolationists—Bastam, Jurix, and Illphres, while Qum was undeclared and Ophelia was a Centrist. That was surprising in itself, given the Isolationist and the Centrist's longstanding rivalry, but apparently they had an understanding.

This was Illphres' group of allies, and Ceria felt out of place and very small sitting with them. But she was here for a reason.

"This is my new apprentice. Ceria. She's annoying, but she'll help get the equipment we need."

That was Illphres' way of introducing Ceria to the group. Jurix laughed as the others greeted Ceria. He put his head on the table to reach over and shake Ceria's hand—she remembered to stare at his head while she shook, rather than at the empty space where his head should have been on a normal body.

"I've seen you about, and of course I saw you fighting those pirates a year ago, Ceria. If you managed to convince Illphres of all people to take you on as an apprentice, I have no doubt you're a capable individual able to do pretty much anything."

Ceria blushed bright red, but Ophelia looked at Illphres with concern.

"Just so long as you're not planning on making her our sixth. That's not your intention, surely?"

Illphres passed her hand over her mouth to smile wryly.

“Hardly. I didn’t want an apprentice and I still don’t. But she insisted.”

“Good. No offense Ceria, but I don’t want you getting killed for nothing.”

Ophelia nodded at Ceria and, confused, the half-Elf nodded back. She hesitated, but then cleared her throat.

“Um, what is this about? I know Illphres said she needed the rings enchanted against ice magic—I have them right here, they’re about Tier 4 enchantments which is the best I could get—but what is it for?”

The mages stared at the rings Ceria put on the table, courtesy of Calvaron and a very large amount of gold, and then at Illphres. After a moment Bastam burst out angrily.

“Ancestors, Illphres! You didn’t *tell* her what we’re going to do?”

Illphres shrugged, smiling wickedly. She seemed to enjoy the others’ consternation.

“Should I have? Teaching her is all I have to do. Why bother telling her something that she can’t change?”

The others groaned and covered their faces, but none of them looked surprised. They too were used to Illphres’ way of doing things. Ceria looked from face to face, wondering what was going on.

“Okay, I’ll tell her. Unless you object?”

The others shook their heads and Jurix turned to Ceria. She heard Ophelia casting a ward against eavesdropping as Jurix put his head on his shoulders and smiled at her. Then he turned and pointed. Ceria followed his finger and saw a Golem, one of the most primitive types, a crude man made of brown stone slowly wheeling out more food on a table.

He put each dish slowly and carefully on a table as students flowed past him, some taking food right off the plate as he paused so as not to bump any of them. He was just one of the many Golems in Wistram, practically the scenery that Ceria had gotten used to.

“See that Golem, Ceria? Well, he’s our enemy. Him and every Golem in Wistram. At the end of the year, Illphres, Bastam, Ophelia, Qum and I are

going to challenge Cognita. We're going to destroy her and open the doors to the rest of Wistram."

He grinned at her. Ceria turned to Illphres and stared into her master's eyes. The ice mage smiled deeply at Ceria. Ceria blinked, looked at the Golem serving food, and then flipped the table.

"What!?"

Golems. They were a rarity in most parts of the world—unless you lived in a desert or if it snowed. Then they were more common, but you'd still only see the weakest, most primitive of Golems. Sand Golems, Snow Golems and so on were functions of nature, of excess mana and intention.

But Golems, the kind that were manufactured and sculpted or built and brought to life with magic, those were different. They were expensive, hideously so, to make, and only a powerful mage could create one.

Well, Ceria supposed even she could make a primitive, small one with work. But to create it would take months of study, and it would be hardly useful. She couldn't imagine the effort needed to create a more advanced Golem.

The half-Elf walked through the halls of Wistram, distracted, hurrying past students without a word. Now that she looked, there were Golems all over Wistram. Okay, not many, not compared to the students, but too many.

A Golem passed her with a basket of laundry in his hands. He was a crude stone one, capable of following basic orders. She stared at him and shuddered as he passed. Okay, he was a simple one, but her idea of 'simple' had been skewed by living here.

A simple Golem? He was capable of obeying most instructions quite well! He could fetch and carry and fight or lift extremely heavy objects if need be. Forget simple, he was worth thousands of gold coins by himself, possibly ten thousand coins alone! An undying, tireless servant capable of

killing lesser warriors with a body made of rock? He was powerful, not simple.

And he was the least of the Golems walking through Wistram. Ceria shuddered as she saw a suit of armor, gleaming and polished, meekly carrying a stack of books while he passed her by. He was a Golem built for war. His steel body was far more agile than the stone Golems and he had a sword and shield. If he used it—

But of course, he wouldn't. Right? The Golems of Wistram had been made to protect and serve by Archmage Zelkyr. And enforce his will. But they were a valuable asset to the academy. They did chores, defended the isle against attack—

And kept the highest parts of the castle under lock and key. Ceria knew that—she'd known it since her first year. But she'd given little thought to it since then.

Wistram's highest corridors and rooms were out of bounds. So what? There was plenty to do below it.

Only—there wasn't. Wistram was only a quarter, or less of what it was. The true magics and real spells that would turn good mages into great ones were all above, locked behind a door guarded by Golems. That was what the five mages had told Ceria as she'd sat in the banquet hall in disbelief.

“You see, Ceria, there is a limit to the heights mages can reach here. Level 50, let alone Level 60, is the utmost limit we can strive towards. People like Archmage Feor or Amerys—they're the top. And yet, it didn't use to be this way. Once, we had real [Archmages].”

“Once we were true mages.”

Jurix and Illphres' voice rang through Ceria's ears. It wasn't hard to understand what they were saying.

Cognita, the Golems of Wistram, they protected the academy. But they also held all mages within hostage. No one could reach beyond a certain level, not without more spells to study. Oh, a mage could study by themselves, but that meant their growth stagnated. In this place they had countless centuries—millennia of experience to draw upon, but it was all out of reach.

Guarded. By Cognita and four other Golems. Sentries, designed to be a test for mages to challenge. All those who had tried before had died, but once again mages had gathered. Five of the most powerful mages of Wistram had come together to challenge the Golem's authority. And they would win or die.

It was too much for Ceria to take in. This was why Illphres needed the rings protecting against ice. She was going to fight alongside the others, and they needed protection from her deadly attacks.

Ceria had seen Illphres fight. She could freeze the air, raise huge structures of ice or hurl massive pillars of it at her enemies. She was going to use that magic to fight Cognita.

It was unthinkable to Ceria. She couldn't believe—well, she *could* believe Illphres would keep it a secret. But the rest?

It was too much for her. That was how Ceria found herself at Pisces' door, pounding on it and demanding to be let in. It took a while and she heard him bumping around inside, but eventually he opened it, glaring.

“Who in the name of—Ceria?”

He let her in, looking bewildered. Ceria stepped into Pisces' room and found chaos. Dirt, mess, fragments of parchment and bits of food—that was the least of it. Ceria saw a pile of bones in the corner and nearly backed out of the room in horror.

“Is that—dead gods, Pisces!”

“It's just mouse bones! Please, Ceria! I'll—let me just clean this up!”

Pisces waved his hands at her, desperately shifting things about with gusts of wind and levitating them into corners or into his dresser. Ceria looked away from the pile of bones, shuddering, and didn't ask where Pisces had put them when he told her she could come back in.

“I'm—sorry. I just—I need to practice, you understand, and I—”

“You're not plundering the catacombs?”

Ceria eyed Pisces. She knew that quite a few mages were buried underneath the academy, even if she'd never dared go exploring for the crypts where their remains—if there were any—were interred. Pisces shook his head.

“I fear that would be...well, let's just say I doubt others would take kindly to the knowledge that I were robbing graves.”

“Yeah, they wouldn't. But *rat* bones?”

“Mice.”

“Is there a difference?”

Pisces shrugged. He fidgeted on his bed as he faced her—he seemed barely able to believe she was here, talking to him.

Ceria had no idea why she was talking to Pisces either. She was so shaken by what she'd just learned she had to speak to someone. And she had unconsciously come here. Now that she was actually facing Pisces, though, she didn't know what to say.

“Well. It's been a while since I last came here.”

“Yes. It has.”

Pisces cleared his throat awkwardly.

“You look well.”

“You look—awful, frankly.”

He blinked, and then smiled at that. Ceria grinned shakily at him. Pisces looked around his dingy room.

“Yes, well, my circumstances have changed quite a lot since—before. My fortunes have fallen, so to speak.”

“Tell me about it.”

He sniffed.

“I hardly think *you* can make the same comparison, given—”

“No, I mean, tell me about it.”

He paused. Ceria looked at him.

“Tell me, Pisces. Tell me everything. And tell me why. And maybe—”

She didn’t say the rest. But slowly, Pisces relaxed his hunched posture. He straightened his back, and looked at Ceria like he used to.

“Well, if you insist...”

“Will you challenge them all at once?”

“We have to. The Golems fight together. Cognita will be there—and four others.”

Ceria stood with Illphres by the ocean, aiming at targets as the sun came up. Across the rocks, Bastam, Jurix, Ophelia and Qum were all doing the same.

She was a part of their group now. Not the same—she was the only apprentice and student among them—but they had no other confidants, no other apprentices to tell. Ceria knew, and this secret was one she’d never reveal.

“It might not matter if you do. But others would try and stop us or get in the way, or make it *political*. We’re doing this to end politics and factions once and for all.”

Illphres aimed at a target, an ice pillar three hundred meters away, the ice tinted red, and shattered it with a single spear of ice. Ceria nodded as she took aim at her own target.

“But I mean, why five of you? Is it because there will be five Golems, including Cognita? Is there a rule of some kind?”

“Rule? No.”

Illphres snorted as she raised more targets out of the sea.

“There’s no rule—other than that if you try, the test doesn’t end until you’re dead or the Golems are destroyed. We could attack them in the hallways if we weren’t afraid of all the Golems joining in. And every mage in Wistram could take on the challenge if they wanted to.”

“They why *don’t* they? Why only you five? If you got five more mages, surely—”

“They won’t try. They’re afraid of dying. Cowards.”

Illphres said it shortly. She shot a flurry of [Glacial Spears] out, shattering a dozen targets at once.

“They are afraid, and content to live like they have. Not us, though. All of us—the Isolationists who aren’t afraid to risk our lives and Ophelia and Qum—we see that mages cannot live like this. We want to grow, not die old at this level. We want to be true mages.”

“True mages.”

The word floated in the air between them. Ceria stared across the ocean and tried to imagine what lay beyond the door. But she couldn’t imagine the door itself.

“I’ve never seen the Golems. You said there are four of them, not counting Cognita?”

Illphres turned.

“Would you like to see?”

The door was stone. Not just any stone, but obsidian, shining and dark as night. Ceria could see it was warded as well. Across the room, it shone with a thousand sigils and runes, twining together to form the most powerful ward she could imagine.

She only dared look at the door from afar at the other end of the massive room, hundreds of feet wide and nearly forty feet high. That was because the guardians stood at the other end.

Three Golems. Ceria only saw three, but each one made her heart quake in her chest. Illphres stood next to her, which was the only reason Ceria didn't run.

One was a Golem made of magma. It burned as the molten rock flowed around it, onto the floor, and back up, covering its body. It was fire incarnate, a core of something so bright it shone through the melting stone glowing at its heart.

The second was a creature of metal, something that looked like no species Ceria could ever dream of. Two thin, curved legs made it stand twenty feet tall. Each leg was incredibly thin and seemed to taper off into an edge like a blade. A narrow, metal body was its torso, roughly the same size as a normal Human's, twenty feet up. It had two arms curved like the legs, half as long, and as sharp as scythes.

It had no face, and the way it stood so still made Ceria uneasy.

The third Golem was a simple one to understand, but no less frightening for it. It was a giant armored Golem, like one of the suits of armor but scaled up on a massive level. This Golem was a colossus, and it held a sword in one hand that was twice as tall as Ceria was and a shield of equal size and weight. It crouched, staring across the room at Ceria.

Only three Golems. Ceria didn't see the fourth. The Golem made of shadows stood next to her, noxious breath wafting over her as its jaws hovered close to her head.

The room stank, despite being clean. It smelled to Ceria of death, or perhaps it was her own fear she smelled. She saw Illphres was gazing at the Golems and shuddered.

When they left the room and the doors closed behind them, Ceria had to sit down in the empty corridor. Her legs had completely given out.

"Terrified?"

“Y—”

Ceria couldn't even form the words to say 'yes'. Illphres nodded.

“Each Golem in there is a masterpiece. A nightmare. Only a true mage could create one of them, let alone four.”

“Four? I saw—”

Ceria closed her mouth as she remembered. She hadn't noticed it, not at all, but one of the Golems had been standing *right next to her*. A thing of shadows and flesh and—

She threw up. Illphres stood next to Ceria dispassionately, but she did magic away the vomit when Ceria was done.

“You noticed it? Good. It took Bastam three tries to figure it out. It *looks* like a Shadow Golem—I'm not even sure if you could make such a thing to begin with, but it's really a Flesh Golem. It's only enchanted to be covered in shadows and mess with the mind.”

“Dead gods. It was right next to me and I—I—”

“Remember them. They're the enemy. But also remember, Cognita will be there as well. And of the five, she's the most dangerous.”

“Cognita?”

Ceria couldn't imagine Cognita stacking up to the Golems she'd seen in that room, for all she was terrifying in her own right. Illphres nodded.

“Don't underestimate her. Truestone Constructs are the pinnacle of Golem creation for a reason. I have no idea what she can do, but I think she'll be the most dangerous. But the others will be just as deadly. At least the armored knight Golem seems easy.”

“Easy? That thing was as big as a *house!*”

“It's not one of the original guardian Golems. I know because records show the original one was destroyed. That's a replacement, one of the Golems that normally defends Wistram. It may look dangerous, but it's not nearly as bad as the others. I could take that one out by myself with no problem.”

Ceria stared at Illphres, but she knew the other woman was serious. That was the difference between her and her master.

“You’re really going to do this?”

“I’ve prepared for this day for over a decade. I gave my life to magic, and I will give my life to this battle if I must. But I believe we will win.”

Illphres smiled then. She looked at Ceria, and the mask of ice betrayed her true feelings. Her cold eyes burned with life.

“This is what we will challenge, Ceria. Don’t you see? This is what it means to be a true mage.”

Ceria saw, but she was still afraid. Illphres helped her up. The woman’s hand was surprisingly small on Ceria’s arm.

“I gave up everything for magic, Ceria. Everything. You saw my face. I’ve made mistakes, hurt myself, but always, always, I strived to reach higher. This is the ceiling I have come against. This is what I must overcome. And I will do it. And when I do, this academy will change. We will change it.”

The half-Elf looked up into the Human woman’s face. She knew, she remembered the fearsome enemies that stood in that room, waiting for their challengers. But she looked into Illphres’ eyes and believed.

“How can I help?”

“Cast the spell, Ceria!”

Jurix screamed at Ceria as spells flashed around her in the largest of the practice rooms. She raised the wand he’d given her and gritted her teeth.

“[Fireball]!”

It was a spell she could only cast with a wand, not being wholly proficient at it. It streaked across the room at Illphres. The woman turned, raising her

hands.

Ceria didn't hear the word, but the fireball exploded, and when she could see, Ceria saw a huge wall of ice. Not just a wall—

A fortress. Illphres stood atop it, throwing magic down at the other mages around her as they besieged her. She raised walls of ice, froze the ground—

It was a battle between the best of mages. And it was only a practice session. Ceria watched as the other four mages slowly wore Illphres down, but it was hard, even for them. At the end she raised her hands in surrender and panting, they walked back towards Ceria to review.

“Those walls you make really are hard to crack, Illphres. I believe we might be able to lock down all the other Golems with it, save for the magma one.”

“And Cognita. She can shatter my ice.”

Illphres was sweating. She nodded at Ceria as the half-Elf passed her a flask of water. Ceria had food and drinks for the other mages, and they thanked her as they kept talking.

“You're sure?”

“Ceria saw her smash through my barrier. It may be I can freeze her if I don't give her room to move her arms—I can cast thicker ice walls than the one she broke—but I won't bet on it.”

“Even so, if we can count on your abilities...”

Afterwards, Ceria talked with Illphres. The woman smiled as Ceria gushed over what she'd seen.

“It was incredible! You held them off, four other mages! Are you higher level? What was that spell?”

“[Fortress of the Ice Queen]. It has other names—it's a famous spell. I'll use it right off in our battle to shield the others.”

“Do you—do you think it'll stop them?”

“Maybe. Maybe not. I'll improvise. It doesn't matter. We don't stick to one plan. We're all experienced mages and we'll find a way to beat them one by

one.”

“I can’t believe how powerful you are. Why aren’t you an Archmage yourself?”

“Don’t want to be.”

Illphres shrugged as Ceria gaped.

“I might be able to, but that’s politics and I told you, I don’t care. Amerys—she’s famous for fighting on battlefields, but I think she’s only got eight levels or so on me. Maybe six.”

“*Six?*”

“Enough. If it came down to a duel between us she’d win.”

That wasn’t what Ceria wanted to hear. Illphres just smacked her on the back of the head.

“Don’t look like that. It’s about our combat styles.”

“What do you mean? You two are friends, right? Why won’t she help you fight? I’m sure she’d love a chance to battle such powerful enemies.”

Illphres snorted and nearly laughed outright.

“Us? *Friends?* What gave you that idea? I can’t stand her.”

“But you train all the time! Every morning I see you two—”

“We’re competing. And yes, we sometimes train together. That’s because we’re a good match. She’s lightning and air and I’m ice and water. She prefers rapid all-out assaults and I use traps and fight drawn out battles. She doesn’t think and I plan every move.”

“Oh.”

“And she won’t join us. I asked.”

“Why not?”

“She’s waiting for her King.”

That was all Illphres said. She and Ceria sat in silence, staring at the melting ice. After a moment, Illphres spoke again.

“If I had a minute to prepare, or if it was a double battle—”

“Yes?”

“I’d win. I’m one of the best mages at fighting defensively. You saw my barriers. That will be my role in the battle. So long as I live, I will protect my teammates.”

So long as I live. Ceria shuddered at the words. They were a frank statement about what might happen. But she didn’t want to think of it.

To distract herself, Ceria went to Pisces more than once over the months that followed. Sometimes she came away happy, relieved that he hadn’t changed. Other times she stormed out of his room after a fight, or left wondering how the earnest young man she’d known had disappeared and been replaced by this thing. But it all came together a month before Illphres and the others planned to challenge the Golems, as Ceria let her anger explode at Pisces.

He was busy showing her the newest spells he’d learned. Ceria tried to focus; she knew Pisces had a terrible time obtaining new spellbooks or learning from anyone. But as her attention wavered from the brilliant [Flame Rapier] spell he had mastered, she stared at something covered with cloth in the corner of the room.

Pisces, engrossed in fencing with the flaming blade, whirled as he heard Ceria shout in surprise. She was backing away from the thing in the corner, the cloth in her hands.

“Ceria!”

She pointed, finger shaking.

“Is that—”

It was a deformed thing, barely recognizable. It was humanoid—barely. It had been made of wet clay that had dried and sculpted to look like a Human, but the sculptor, Pisces, was untrained and so the body was lumpy and the arms deformed. It had two stumps for legs.

“Ah, I see you’ve found my latest work. I was going to show you, but—”

“Pisces! *What is it?*”

He looked surprised at Ceria’s reaction.

“A Golem. One of my own creations. Don’t be alarmed; it’s barely functional. Worthless, really. Can’t you tell? I admit, the workmanship might be a tad shoddy, but—”

“*Get rid of it!*”

Ceria backed away from the clay thing. Pisces frowned at her.

“What? Don’t be alarmed, Ceria, it’s not animated!”

She rounded on him furiously.

“What are you doing, making a Golem? Aren’t there enough around here?”

He took a step back and stammered as Ceria shouted at him.

“Well, I was taught.”

“By *who?*”

“Cognita.”

The word doused the flames of Ceria’s anger in a second. She felt a chill in her stomach and stepped back from Pisces.

“Explain.”

“Well I—I’ve been talking with her, Ceria. You see, Cognita’s one of the only people—beings—in this academy who will give me the time of day. She’s quite brilliant, you know. She’s seen more magic than anyone in Wistram, and she taught me so many things about Golems and mage craft. She taught me how to make this Golem. Did you know that she thinks I have real aptitude? She even—”

“Don’t talk to her! Don’t go near her!”

“What? Why?”

“She’s the *enemy!*”

Ceria shouted at Pisces. He didn’t understand, and she couldn’t explain. She stomped over to his Golem and punched it. The brittle clay broke under her fist and Pisces shouted.

“What are you doing? Do you know how hard I worked to—”

“Why are you doing this?”

Ceria turned to Pisces. She thrust a finger in his chest, making him stumble back. His face was red with anger, but she was even more furious.

“First necromancy, now—*this?* Why can’t you practice normal magic? Why can’t you just be a normal mage? Everyone would accept you then! Why don’t you get a normal master and stop—”

“Don’t you think I’ve *tried?*”

Pisces shoved Ceria’s hand away. She blinked. His eyes were wide and bloodshot. Pisces nearly shouted, his voice cracking with passion.

“I’ve gone to every mage—every one I know or thought would consider having me as an apprentice. I’ve asked—none of them were willing to teach me even when I told them I’d swear off necromancy as long as I studied under them! No one will teach me, and I’m not going to afford the fees for next year! Don’t you understand!?”

After his outburst there was silence. Ceria stared at Pisces and slowly sank back into his chair. He couldn’t look at her.

“Necromancy? That’s just raising the dead. Some might object, but it’s no curse. But the fools who claim to be mages here treat it as such. Thus, I suppose the curse is indeed real—though by the prejudices and limited understanding of others.”

“You’re going to leave?”

He looked at her, on the brink of tears.

“I have to. I have no coin, no one to speak for me. The only hope I have is a master, but who would take me as their apprentice?”

Ceria’s mind raced. The words came out before she could think about it.

“Illphres. My master. She might.”

Pisces stared at her, but then shook his head, closing his eyes.

“She will say no. I know Illphres—she would never agree.”

“I could ask—”

“She’ll say no.”

Pisces turned away. He walked back over to the broken Golem and stared at it.

“Leave me, Springwalker. I am—busy. I have work to do, especially if this year is to be my last.”

She stared at him, and then slowly walked out of the room. Only after she felt a bit of liquid dripping from her hand did she realize the clay Golem’s shards had cut her skin.

“Take Pisces on as an apprentice? No. Don’t be stupid.”

Illphres looked at Ceria as though she were mad when Ceria brought it up to her the next day. The two were sitting on the edge of the walkway above the ocean.

Just sitting. Ceria had gotten over her fear of heights, mainly because Illphres had made her come up here to practice. A mage could have no weaknesses, after all. She stared down at the sea below, fighting her belly.

“Why not? He’s smart, gifted—he needs a master or he won’t be able to stay!”

“Too bad, I guess. But I’m not teaching him.”

“*Why?*”

Illphres took her time in replying. She’d grown—not warmer, but maybe a bit softer towards Ceria over the year. In the last month, she was downright friendly at times. Both could feel it. The time of the challenge was approaching fast.

“He’s not my type.”

Ceria nearly tumbled off the bridge in shock. Illphres clarified after giving Ceria a smack on the arm.

“I mean that he will never be an ice mage. You might, or at least, you’ll learn Skills and change your class from what I’ve taught you. But that boy is a [Necromancer] through and through. I don’t feel like teaching someone who won’t follow in my footsteps.”

“But if you’d speak for him—”

“I don’t need to. And none of the others will take him on as an apprentice either, Ceria.”

“*Why?* Pisces is—”

“Don’t you understand? After the end of this month, none of it will matter.”

Ceria’s eyes widened. Illphres nodded.

“That’s right. After the challenge, i—*when* we win, all of the bickering , factions and the politics...”

She paused.

“Well, it’ll probably go on as normal. But we’ll be on top.”

“How? If you defeat the Golems—”

“We’ll prove that our way works. Mages will rally to us, and those that don’t will have to fight to venture higher. But we’ll be guarding the entrance. It might be a war, or it might be quiet, but the Council won’t sit

and pass decisions any longer. It will be every mage for themselves, as it used to be. As it should be.”

Ceria tried to imagine it. She thought of Calvaron and Beatrice fighting for more power and shook her head.

“I think things might still be the same.”

“Really? You might be right. We’ll see. But one thing I can promise you: when we open the higher levels of Wistram up, I’ll use my influence. You, Pisces, and all the other mages who have a spine and a brain will stay.”

“As the Isolationists?”

“As mages. True mages.”

That was all Illphres said. Ceria stared at her, and realized that Illphres was the first Human she’d ever known that she truly looked up to. She’d admired Pisces for his brilliance, but Illphres was different. She was actually a bit younger than Ceria, but she felt so much older. She shone, and she stood higher than the half-Elf, reaching for the stars.

Ceria couldn’t say any of this out loud, of course. If she did Illphres would probably toss her into the ocean. Instead, she just turned and stared at the dark night sky.

“When the day comes, I’ll be waiting for you outside the doors. So make sure you finish the battle quickly, okay? I don’t feel like waiting long.”

“Insolent girl.”

Illphres’ voice was amused. Ceria didn’t look at her, but she knew the woman was smiling.

“I’ll take as long as I please. And when it’s over I’ll make you practice twice as hard learning all the spells you need to be halfway competent.”

“Promise?”

The woman was silent for a long time. After a while, she sighed.

“Of course.”

They stared out across the ocean. Ceria felt a humming in her bones, a tightness in her chest that didn't go away when she slept. She felt as though she could run a thousand miles from sheer nervous energy, and that she didn't want to move a muscle at the same time.

There was one month left. One month.

Until it would all be over.

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Wistram Days (Pt.7)

Her name was Cognita. That was what she told the people she met.

Her name was Cognita. She had once been shaped and given life by Archmage Zelkyr, the greatest expert in Golem creation of his era. Perhaps ever. Because Cognita was a Truestone Golem.

The word itself was a symbol of her authority. Truestone Golems or Truestone Constructs as they were once known were thought to be the pinnacle of artificial creation. For if Cognita was not the strongest Golem that could be made, she alone had what other Golems lacked. Personality. Thought. Feeling.

Perhaps even a soul.

But who could tell? Few people found Golems reassuring, despite their usefulness. And Cognita was feared for reasons beyond just her nature.

She killed mages. She had killed hundreds, perhaps thousands. And yet she was subservient, helpful, polite. So those who met her were both terrified and confused by her, because a monster should *look* and *act* like a monster.

But what Cognita actually thought was a mystery. At all times her carved eyes judged and saw, but never gave away anything. She had seen countless mages, seen their triumph and their end. She looked at two more now.

One was a half-Elf, the other a Human. Both were young by the standards of their species. Once, they had been friends. The Golem saw traces of it still, even as they argued.

“They won’t ever let you stay. Not after what you said.”

“They haven’t accepted me thus far, Springwalker. Why should those fools change their minds now?”

“Don’t call me Springwalker! And you know damn well there’s a difference between keeping your head down and poking the beehive!”

Pisces and Ceria were shouting in front of Cognita, a rarity in itself. Few people raised their voices anywhere around the Golem, but Pisces knew Cognita. He alone had sought her out, asked her questions, befriended her.

Ceria just didn't care. She was close to kicking the mage—again. He hopped away from her, glaring.

"Those philistines that make up the so-called Council—they are blind to what I proposed, but you at least should be able to consider the implications of what I've said!"

"Implications? You want to create an undead that can *level*, Pisces! You're an idiot! If you succeeded you'd destroy the world, but that won't happen because it's impossible!"

He raised a shaking finger. He was angry. He was always angry, and hurt, of late. So was the half-Elf. Together, Cognita saw fury and fear on both sides clashing together.

"It is possible. In theory! Didn't you listen to my proposal? If I were to create an undead by weaving the spells into it on a much more in-depth level than normal—something closer to how a Golem is created than a body is animated—it might work!"

"It's *stupid*."

"What's wrong with that idea? I have all the pieces of the puzzle in my possession—almost. Cognita taught me the formula used for embodying Golems with sentience, don't you see? That alone—"

"Only you would be stupid enough to ask! Cognita is—"

Pause. The half-Elf's face shifted towards Cognita and the Golem saw her red cheeks pale slightly. She looked away rather than meet the Golem's gaze.

"Sorry, Cognita. But Pisces—you're a fool. It would never work. Why hasn't a [Necromancer] done it before? Two reasons. One—it's stupid and the second is that if the undead could level, they'd destroy entire nations!"

"I would only make one. And it *is* possible, but only with the correct base materials."

Pisces' voice was calm. He stared at his former friend, speaking with the conviction that was halfway into insanity. He glanced at Cognita too, but his gaze was burning. He looked at the Golem not as a threat or something to be feared, but as a challenge. A vision of what could be done.

"Golems require high-grade materials to be built. Mana stones, rock without impurity—Cognita, if I may refer to your construction, you are a product of both spellcraft and the superior base products from which you were given life. So why not apply that theory in the case of the undead?"

Most bodies are just that, bodies. But if there were a way to obtain superior parts—”

“Parts?”

Cognita turned back to look at the half-Elf. She was furious. And the Golem knew the conversation was over. Ceria pointed a shaking finger at Pisces.

“You’re—disgusting. And insane. And I don’t have time to argue with you. If you want to go spouting off crazy theories, go ahead. I’m going to practice real magic.”

She stormed off. Pisces called to her once as she left, but Ceria did not turn her head. He turned back to Cognita in frustration.

“I’m sorry you had to witness that, Cognita. Please, accept my apologies. I thought I could convince Ceria with your help, but she is unwilling to listen to reason.”

Cognita made no immediate reply. She could have told Pisces a thousand things, spoken from decades of observation. Some would help, others might shatter the young man. After a moment, Cognita made a decision and spoke while looking Pisces in the eye.

“She cannot accept what you do. And you cannot accept that she does not consider you a friend. Perhaps the question is then whether you value friendship or magic more.”

He was speechless. He opened his mouth to respond, but Cognita strode down the hallway after Ceria.

“Ceria Springwalker.”

If it had been Pisces or anyone else, Ceria would have ignored them or shoved them aside. But Cognita’s deep, inflectionless voice made her tense in sudden fear. She turned, trying to conceal the fear in her heart.

“Yes, Cognita?”

“I believe Pisces would like me to express his apologies in his stead. However, I will not do so. I would merely like to speak with you for a few more moments if you have time.”

Ceria paused. She was still furious at Pisces, livid. His presentation to the Council had set Wistram in an uproar, and he was now more of a pariah than he had been before.

That wasn't the only reason she was so angry, though. The day Illphres would challenge Archmage Zelkyr's Golems was only two weeks away. And so Ceria was angry, frightened, and nervous. But she tried to hide all that from Cognita.

The Golem was the enemy.

"Talk to me? I—sure, Cognita. Why do you want to talk?"

"Hearing your reactions and thoughts intrigues me. I was created to think and learn, and this topic—and your discussion—is interesting to me in a way few things are."

That was extraordinary. And unhelpful. Ceria stared at Cognita as if searching for a weak point. But the stone woman was flawless.

"I guess I can talk."

"Very well. Thank you."

The Golem fell silent. After a few seconds of awkwardness, Ceria realized Cognita was waiting for her to speak. Ceria didn't know what to say. She'd said what she thought. Pisces was insane. His idea was insane. But Cognita—

She glanced up at the Golem. Cognita's face seldom changed, but Ceria could remember her smiling just once.

"Cognita? Did you really teach Pisces one of Archmage Zelkyr's spells?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

The Truestone Construct—the thing that had a name and a mind—paused.

"He asked. And it was an incomplete spell. I believe Pisces has a chance of completing it. In his own way."

Another revelation. This one hurt Ceria's heart. It was one thing to know Pisces was smart, acknowledge that he could do things Ceria could not. He was a genius, but this? Pisces had a chance to do what Archmage Zelkyr could not. Cognita had said so. It made Ceria doubt the angry words she had spoken to him.

"Do you support him doing necromancy? Do you even care?"

"I see in his magic something akin to what mages do when they shape Golems, but different. I care not if they are dead bodies or clay and stone that is shaped. I believe his ideas are intriguing. I wonder if he will be able to do as he claims. Even for Zelkyr, the only creation he was able to imbue

with true intelligence was a Truestone Golem, my kind. What base material would be equivalent among the dead?”

Ceria had no idea. But she shivered again to think of a walking thing, some shambling zombie with rotting flesh that could grow stronger. What if it could talk? What if it could think, like Cognita? A talking, leveling undead was too close to an actual person, yet indescribably far away from life at the same time.

“I don’t know if Pisces can do it. But I feel like it’s wrong. That’s all I can say. I’m sorry. I have to go.”

She didn’t want to look at Cognita anymore. The Golem nodded.

“I will leave you to your business after mentioning one last issue. The day when your master and four other mages plan to challenge me is fifteen days away. I trust they are all prepared and aware of the consequences of failure?”

The breath caught in Ceria’s chest. She stared back at Cognita, eyes wide. How did the Golem *know*?

“That—that’s right. They know. My master knows.”

Cognita nodded once again.

“Please inform her that if she or any of the other mages desire to wait or change the appointed time, I would be happy to do so. Good night, Ceria Springwalker.”

She turned and began to walk away. Ceria took one look at Cognita’s back and fled.

“You *told* Cognita when you’d be challenging her?”

Illphres looked up with a frown as Ceria slammed the door behind her and stormed into the room.

“Told who?”

“*Cognita!*”

Ceria clutched at her hair. She’d run all the way to Illphres’ room. The mage shrugged.

“Oh, yes. We told her.”

“*Why?*”

“It’s convenient. It means she knows and won’t be busy, and it means we can’t back out.”

“But if she knows, she could set traps. Prepare—”

“She won’t. She never has and never will. But this way we won’t alert the entire academy when Cognita goes striding up to the top floor.”

Illphres was too calm. She was always calm. She held a book with a light blue bound cover in her hands, glancing at the page and at Ceria as she spoke. It was her personal spellbook.

“Calm down. Stop pacing. It’s annoying.”

Ceria stopped. She whirled and looked at her master.

“Tell me you can do it.”

Illphres sighed and closed the book. She stared at the ceiling, and then looked at Ceria.

“We have a chance.”

“How do you know?”

“Because it was nearly done once.”

“Really?”

Ceria’s ears perked up. Illphres nodded.

“A group of mages nearly succeeded. So we can too.”

“But how do you know? Is there a history or—”

“A few records of challenges, but no. We can tell just from the Golems in the room. Sit. Think about how we can tell.”

Ceria sat unwillingly. She fidgeted, and then came up with the only explanation she could think of.

“The missing Golem. The one replaced by the armored knight one.”

“Exactly. That’s proof.”

“But that’s only one of the five Golems—”

“No, it’s a sign. Think.”

Illphres sighed as her tone grew waspish. She hated explaining things when she thought Ceria should understand.

“Any idiot could figure it out. Archmage Zelkyr made this challenge for any mages trying to reach the higher floors, didn’t he? He designed it to be challenged over and over again, which meant that he would expect his four guardian Golems—plus Cognita—to never be destroyed. They would fight in tandem and overwhelm their opponents without sustaining enough damage to be destroyed.”

“So the missing Golem—”

“It’s a sign that someone broke their formation. And nearly won, too. Because if they could isolate one of the Golems long enough to destroy it, it

meant they could hold off the rest. None of those Golems would be easy to disassemble with any one spell.”

“And that means you can all do the same. Easier, especially if one of the Golems is weaker...”

Ceria sat up, eyes shining. Illphres nodded calmly.

“We can do it. There is a possibility.”

“That makes me feel better. I was talking with Cognita—”

Slowly, Ceria explained her argument to Illphres. The mage rolled her eyes when Ceria was done.

“I heard about that. Levelling undead? I don’t see why everyone’s so upset. ”

“But—”

“It’s no different from anyone else leveling up. A half-Elf can live for centuries if they want, how’s that different from an undead? It sounds like it would be hard to make more than one or two. If they get out of hand you can destroy them. The real reason you’re upset is because you hate necromancy.”

Ceria bit her lip and made no reply. Illphres sighed.

“Necromancy is magic. I don’t fear your friend. He reanimates the dead. I freeze people. And I hardly look better than the undead. You have seen beneath my mask. You know that.”

“It’s not the same.”

“No?”

Illphres raised an eyebrow.

“Magic is magic, and that boy Pisces was your friend, once. Does knowing he practices necromancy change all that?”

“Yes!”

“I suppose you weren’t good friends, then. Enough.”

Illphres waved away Ceria’s objections and levitated the book in her hands over to the half-Elf.

“Study the [Glacial Spear] spell. I want you to make at least *some* progress before the challenge day.”

“I’d learn more if you let me keep the book! Or made me a copy!”

Ceria complained as she bent over the pages of tightly-written text. Illphres laughed sardonically.

“Copy the book? I don’t know how to write magical spells down. That’s a specialist class, [Magical Scribe] or some such. And it would take a Level

40 one to write that spell down.”

“Really?”

Ceria looked up with a frown. Illphres nodded. She began lecturing as Ceria listened with one ear and read with both her eyes.

“Spellbooks are rare because they can’t be copied without extensive study by a powerful mage, or a class with similar Skills. And scribing a spell is only possible for someone of an equal or higher level than the spell itself. So a Tier 4 spells might be rare but findable in a given collection of spellbooks, but Tier 6 would be extremely difficult to locate. And Tier 8—”

“How would anyone learn the spells, then?”

“By piecing together clues left by other mages, following instructions in languages other than magic to come up with it. Or by leveling and obtaining it or coming up with such a spell themselves.”

“So this spellbook—”

“Is mine.”

“Can you let me borrow—”

“No.”

Two weeks was too long and too short for Ceria. She went through each day emotionally and mentally exhausted, and tossed and turned each night with nervous, physical energy.

That also led to her actively avoiding her friends, and them avoiding her. Ceria was waspish, irritable, and prone to snap at anything and everything. She confined herself to her room when she wasn’t with Illphres or the other mages.

Three days before the challenge, Ceria was in her room, almost out of her mind with the agony of waiting. She heard a knock at the door and snapped.

“Come in already!”

Pisces entered. Ceria snapped again.

“Get out!”

“Please, just listen!”

His eyes were sparkling and Pisces was rubbing his hands together. He looked like he had in the past, full of life and enthusiasm. Ceria couldn’t bear to see it, not now, not when she was so anxious.

“Pisces, I’m not in the mood—”

“Hear me out, hear me out I implore you! I was just talking with Cognita—”

It was the last name Ceria wanted to hear right now, but Pisces couldn’t know that. She tried to stare a hole in his face as he talked excitedly onwards.

“She and I were discussing intelligence, cognizance and how only she among all the Golems has it. I opined that it was a mystery why Zelkyr would have failed with other Golems when she revealed this to me! Archmage Zelkyr only imbued Cognita with the capacity for thought. But over the years the other Golems have achieved a low level of intelligence, at least communally.”

Ceria just stared at Pisces, arms crossed, trying to decode his words. He stared at her, practically shining with energy.

“Don’t you see what this means? The Golems in Wistram *can* think! They can learn to think, that is! And if there’s a possibility of them learning, why not in a creation designed for that capacity? Why, we know that feral Ghouls can think in a primitive hunter-predator sense, and other undead like Crypt Lords, Liches, and Revenants can all—”

“I don’t want to hear it.”

Ceria cut Pisces off flatly. He looked astonished. She stared at him.

“I don’t want to hear it. I don’t want to hear about Cognita—I want you to get out!”

Pisces stopped. He stepped back, looking hurt and offended. He half-turned towards her open door as if he was going to storm out, and changed his mind. Instead, he turned towards her, and spoke pleadingly. She didn’t want to hear, but his words washed over her.

“Ceria, I don’t understand why you’re not giving me a chance to speak. I’m trying to prove a point. I know you have objections to my—to what I do, but please, listen! My goal isn’t to destroy the world or create armies like Az’kerash. When I practice necromancy, the reason I started was—”

It was too much. Ceria interrupted Pisces with the only thing she could use. The truth.

“They’re going to challenge her.”

He stopped, frowning.

“Who?”

Ceria knew she shouldn't tell him. But now the dam had burst and she let it out. It was a relief and terrifying to say it out loud.

"Illphres. Jurix. Bastam. Ophelia. Qum. They're all part of a group—they've been training all year and they're going to challenge Zelkyr's Golems to go to the higher levels."

The half-Elf stared down at her hands, at her bitten fingernails. She saw Pisces sit down hard on the side of her bed out of the corner of her eyes.

"When?"

"It's going to be three days from now. Right before lunch."

Her breath caught in her chest at the words. It was out. The secret was spoken, and now Ceria felt it pressing down on her harder than before. Pisces spoke quietly.

"Illphres and four others? They're serious?"

Ceria nodded. Pisces went still. She could feel him close to her. A familiar presence. Comforting.

"I would advise you to stop them. If I thought they would listen. Cognita is—an unknown quantity. I believe she is more than a match for any of the Archmages of today by herself."

"Yeah. She probably is."

Ceria hugged her knees to her chest and rocked back and forth a bit. She nodded and then shook her head.

"But they're going to do it. Illphres is going to fight. I can't stop her. I wouldn't dare try. She has to do this, don't you see, Pisces? If we can't go above, we can't be true mages. Wistram is stagnant. We don't have real Archmages, just fakes! Don't you see—"

"I know."

Pisces cut her off shortly. Ceria looked and saw he was staring at his feet as he sat on her bed.

"I know. Wistram is decaying. Magic is not as powerful as it was before Zelkyr. Powerful, yes, and one could argue there are more mages being produced by the academy as a result of the Golem's presence, but—I know. And I believe Cognita knows this too."

"She does?"

"We have spoken about it. On occasion."

Ceria grabbed for Pisces. He jerked, but she yanked at his dirty robes. Part of his shoulder and chest became exposed as he fought to loosen her death grip.

“Ceria—”

“Don’t warn her. I mean, she knows, but don’t tell her anything. She’s —”

“I won’t. It wouldn’t matter if I did. Cognita wouldn’t cheat. She’s waiting for a mage to—Ceria, please. I won’t tell anyone.”

Slowly, Ceria let go. Pisces adjusted his robes and the two fell into silence. After a few minutes, Pisces spoke again.

“Thank you for telling me. I won’t reveal a thing. I promise.”

“Thank you.”

“And I hope—I most sincerely hope Illphres and the others defeat Cognita. I would like you to know that, Ceria.”

“I do.”

They stared at each other. It had been a long time since Ceria really met Pisces’ eyes. He looked older, she realized. In a few short years he’d grown older, from a late teenager into a young man. Older, more tired, more bitter.

But still him.

Pisces looked away first. He stood up, brushing himself off and then realizing he was in Ceria’s room and stopping.

“I’ve got to go. I’ll leave you to—we can talk later, Ceria.”

He began to leave but stopped. Ceria was holding on to the back of his robe.

“Don’t go.”

He looked back at her, eyes wide. Ceria stared at him. Slowly, Pisces sat back down.

“The door’s open.”

“Yes.”

Ceria said it without really caring. She and Pisces sat together with the open doorway leading out into the corridor. Part of her told her she was an idiot for blurting out all those secrets, but Ceria knew few people ventured down this hallway, especially at night.

She didn’t stand up to close the door. And neither did Pisces. Eventually, the door did get closed, by magic. But no one left the room until the next morning.

The day of the challenge Ceria couldn't eat. Everything leading up to this day seemed like a brief dream, something someone else had experienced. But what was worse was the day itself.

It was too normal. It was too quiet. It was too—
Peaceful.

It wasn't a holiday. Classes went on like normal, and mages gathered in the corridors, gossiping. They ate in the banquet halls, and walked about as if they had not a care in the world.

Ceria skipped all her classes. She'd skipped the last eight days in truth, spending all her time with Illphres and the other mages. Now she ate breakfast with them, or rather, watched them eat with her stomach trying to shove itself back out her mouth.

"Eat something, Ceria. We can't have you fainting when we walk out of there."

Jurix pressed an apple into Ceria's hand. She looked at it and turned green. He snatched it away.

"Okay, don't eat. I'll do it for you."

"Watch it, Jurix. Don't eat too much. We'll probably be moving around a lot."

Bastam warned the Dullahan as he ate sparingly from a bowl filled with oats and honey. His tail was wagging back and forth faster than normal, but he appeared calm. So did the others. They were far too calm compared to Ceria, who looked as pale as a Selphid by now.

"I think I'll pull out my stomach before we go in. I'll be lighter that way."

Ophelia murmured as she spooned some gravy sparingly over her breakfast of eggs and bacon. Did her hands shake a bit? She smiled at Ceria and the butterflies danced in the girl's stomach.

"Bah. You lot don't know anything. Dullahans know to eat a big meal the day of a battle and a small one later. Isn't that right, Qum?"

Jurix stared across the table at the other Dullahan. He preferred to eat with his head on his shoulders, an oddity for a Dullahan. Qum nodded and spoke softly.

"Proper intake is key."

Illphres glared at the two. She was eating sparingly as well.

"Just so long as you pass it before noon. If you think I'm fighting a battle alongside two constipated Dullahans—"

Everyone laughed. It was a rare joke—actually, not a joke since Illphres said it. But it was what they needed. Ceria tried to smile and failed. She fidgeted in her chair, and checked the position of the sun through a window. When it was right overhead, the challenge would begin. But it felt like it was frozen in the air! She looked back at Jurix as the Dullahan made a joke.

And then—it seemed to Ceria as if she remembered walking around with the others in a blur, listening to them talk. But suddenly, disconcertingly, she was standing in front of the two doors that led into the challenge room, as if the day had gone in an instant.

It was time.

The hallway was simple. Long and straight, it let people come up either stairway at both ends of the corridor. In the middle of the hallway, two double doors sat in the stone wall, the only entrance to the upper floors.

The five mages and Ceria gathered there, but not in silence. Each one was nervous now, and Ceria could sense it. But none of them gave voice to that worry. They joked instead, or stood calmly, or shook hands or claws. They formed up in front of the door, but not before stopping to speak to Ceria of all people.

She was their lone witness. The mages had told no one else that today was the day, and none of them had apprentices. Ophelia was the first to hold Ceria's hand, smiling warmly. The stitches around her mouth pulled as she kissed Ceria on the cheek, to the half-Elf's shock.

"Once this is over I might have to teach you a bit as well. It'll all be different, Ceria. I promise. Mages will change. This place will change."

"I'll be waiting for you to shake my hand. So don't go anywhere—this won't take long."

Jurix grasped Ceria's hand tightly as he looked her in the eye. She nodded, throat too constricted to speak.

Bastam was next.

"You know, I saw your exam. I thought that you had courage then, courage and daring. I thought to myself, that's what we've forgotten, all the older mages. I'll show you we have it today."

He passed her by and Qum was there. The Dullahan bowed his torso to Ceria and then held up his head. He regarded her solemnly.

"Luck to us all."

Illphres was last. She and Ceria stood apart from the others as the mages began casting spells. Ward spells, spells to increase their physical condition

or protect against attacks. Illphres cast no spells. Hers was already active.

The walls of the corridor were already frosting over with ice. Ceria began to shiver and shake uncontrollably as the temperature around Illphres lowered and lowered again. The other mages weren't affected—they all had artifacts to protect them against her cold, but Ceria didn't have any.

Illphres looked at Ceria without an expression on her face, but then she let the ice reshape her lips into a smile.

"Seems like I need to increase your training if you're cold from only this much. Remind me once I'm out."

Ceria tried to smile, but her lips couldn't move. Illphres stared at the double doors, and Ceria felt the chill around her grow deeper. It was so cold. But the mage's voice was light when she spoke next.

"If I was an adventurer, if I had gone out into the world and fought monsters and gone into dungeons for a few years, maybe I wouldn't be so scared now."

"What?"

The woman turned back to Ceria, smiling.

"I grew up in Wistram. I spent my life here. But perhaps if I'd gone out into the world and gained more experience—well, I'd probably be scared all the same. There are wonders and horrors in this world, Ceria, remnants from the ages when gods still lived, memories of empires long gone. This is one of them. And today we will challenge the power of one of the true [Archmages] of Wistram."

"I know you'll succeed. I know it."

Illphres just smiled. She put a hand on Ceria's shoulder and the half-Elf shivered. Illphres looked deep into Ceria's eyes as she whispered to the young half-Elf.

"Remember this, Ceria. For good or bad it matters not. In tragedy or triumph it is the same. Today you will stare into the heart of it."

She smiled at Ceria. Her hand was cool on the half-Elf's shoulder. Cold to the touch, but not freezing. The ice thickened on the walls around Illphres. She looked into the half-Elf's eyes.

"This is *magic*."

Then she turned away. Jurix stepped up to the doors and glanced to his left and right. Illphres stood next to him on his left with Qum further down, Bastam and Ophelia on the right.

"Ready?"

They nodded. Jurix took a breath, and then put his hands on the double doors. He pushed, and they flew open.

As one, the five mages stepped into the room that lay beyond. Ceria took a step towards their backs, but dared go no further.

The Golems of Zelkyr waited in the room beyond. She caught a glimpse of five figures, standing on the other edge of the room. A golem made of burning rock. A metal reaper standing tall and silent. A behemoth knight made of metal. A dark thing already bounding across the room, quiet, panting.

And Cognita, standing tall and proud against the obsidian doors, arms outstretched.

Welcoming the challengers.

Then the doors slammed shut and Ceria saw nothing else. Heard nothing else.

The challenge had begun and she could only wait. If there were any gods, Ceria would have prayed. But she could only hope.

It felt like time stopped after the doors closed. Ceria stared at them, and then wondered what she should do. Sit down? No—she wanted to be standing when everyone came out.

But how long would it take? Suddenly, Ceria was consumed by that question. She shivered in the freezing air as she stared at the double doors. Not a sound passed from the room beyond. She couldn't tell what was happening. She could only imagine.

What would happen first? Would Cognita speak before the battle began, give the mages one last chance to turn back? Would Illphres or the others speak? She wasn't one for speeches, but Jurix might say something, or Bastam.

How long would that take if they did that? Or—what if the fight began the instant the mages stepped into the room? Would it be over in seconds?

Surely not. Either way—Illphres would slow them down with ice. She'd create barriers. It would be impossible to kill her and the others in an instant. They were already warded and prepared for battle.

So how long would it take to destroy the Golems? Ceria guessed as she shivered in front of the door. The ice generated by Illphres' field of cold

was still coating the walls, overwhelming Ceria's own ability to nullify the chill.

When would it be over? No—when would the mages come out? Because, surely, they might rest after the battle. Ceria tried to calculate the time it would take.

Magical battles were rarely long, but this one was different. So...five minutes? That was far too short. Ten? Twenty?

Ceria waited. She knew the minutes were passing as she tried to put a number to her fear. After five minutes she felt relieved. Or told herself she was relieved.

Five was too short. If it was over in five, it would mean they were—

No, no. Not five. Obviously not. Ten, then? It still felt too quick. Or was it too long? Ten minutes, with every mage in there throwing their best spells at the Golems?

After ten minutes, the fear in Ceria's belly turned into spikes that tried to push themselves out from within. A little thought in her head began to whisper to Ceria. It was too long. They were taking too long. Wouldn't she have noticed something, seen some change if the Golems were falling? If it was silent like this for so long, it would mean...

No, no! Illphres was an expert at drawn out battles. This was just playing into her hands. Ceria kept telling herself that. She'd be locking down the Golems with ice, creating fortifications they had to battle past. A long wait was good—they might have to wear down the metal knight Golem, or Cognita. It didn't mean—

Drip.

It was a faint sound, but the only one in the corridor. Ceria whirled. She saw a single tear of water fall from the ceiling. It splashed with the faintest of noises in the corridor. She looked up.

The ice on the walls was melting. Illphres' ice was beginning to melt, slowly gathering condensation into droplets that fell down around Ceria. A few fell around her, and then one landed on her neck.

She jumped as if she'd been struck. Ceria turned her attention back to the door, trying to ignore the melting ice. But it kept melting, more and more of it, as the chill lessened and the walls became slick.

The melted ice puddled on the stone floor, wet, cold. Ceria stared at the door as the last of the ice turned to water. Minutes passed, too many. She felt the water touch her shoes.

And she knew.

But she told herself she didn't. Ceria lied to herself, promising her rapidly beating heart that the doors would open at any moment and Illphres and the others would come out, beaming, battered, but alive. They couldn't be dead. They couldn't be.

But soon the fear in her heart turned to a suppressed panic in her chest. Ceria wanted to scream, but didn't dare to. She wanted to run, but there was no one to run to. The lie in her mind became something else. So long as the doors didn't open they were alive. So long as the double doors were closed, they were still fighting. They were still—

The doors opened. Ceria stepped back from them and nearly slipped. She blinked her eyes, willing the figures to be Illphres, Jurix, Ophelia, Bastam and Qum—

Cognita walked out of the double doors, her stone body whole and undamaged. Ceria stared at her.

And her heart broke.

The Golem saw Ceria standing by herself in the corridor and stopped. She stared down at Ceria, and said not a word. At last, Ceria looked at the doors.

“Are they—are—”

She had to ask, though she knew the answer. Cognita nodded. She spoke softly.

“They failed the challenge. They are dead.”

“It's not true.”

Ceria started towards the doors. She couldn't believe it. It couldn't be. Cognita could *not* be here, undamaged. She had to be injured, destroyed. She couldn't be—

“Ceria Springwalker. I would advise you not to go within.”

“Let go of me!”

Ceria tried to push Cognita's hand away, but the Golem was immovable. The half-Elf squirmed out of the grip and ran for the doors as Cognita let go. She pushed desperately on them, felt them give.

Ceria flung open the doors and stared at what lay beyond.

Pisces heard the scream and knew. In truth he had known thirty minutes ago what the outcome would be. It wasn't anything the mages had shown him.

It was the look in Cognita's eyes.

It was a small clue, but one the young man understood. He alone had talked to Cognita. He had seen how her face changed. Very little, but she too had expressions. She felt. And ironically, Golems were bad liars.

Cognita had feelings. She could feel passion for something, and he had seen her eyes change when he spoke of his ambitions, of what might be done with magic that had never been attempted before. He had seen the spark in her eyes.

But he hadn't seen it as she strode into the chamber. She had known how the battle would end. She had taken the measure of her opponents and seen what would occur without fail.

If Pisces could have, he would have stopped the five mages. He nearly broke his spell of [Invisibility] to try, but one look into their eyes told him they wouldn't be stopped. They didn't care that he was there. They'd seen him, all of them, he was sure. And they'd known from his face what their chances were.

But they'd gone anyways. Because they couldn't turn back. Because they were true mages.

And now they were dead. And Ceria—

He saw Cognita carrying the half-Elf out of the room. She fought the Golem, punching her, casting spells, but Cognita ignored her. Pisces heard Cognita's voice as she told Ceria that if the half-Elf entered the room and fought the Golems she would be killed. And he saw her head turn and knew that was meant for him as well.

Pisces couldn't look at Ceria as she collapsed on the ground. Instead, he slipped away when he saw the group of five lesser Golems enter the room and exit with bags of holding. He knew what they were doing.

He knew where they carried the dead.

Mages died in Wistram. Not as often as one might think, but enough so that it was not rare. Failed experiments, duels gone wrong, simple suicide or accidents like slipping down stairs—

And of course, those who failed the challenge. Pisces walked after the Golems, noting how other students passed them, oblivious to what the Golems carried. They were just things to most of the mages.

But the Golems had purpose, and they fulfilled all manner of tasks. Such as finding a place for the dead.

The catacombs of Wistram were extensive, dark, and off-limits for Pisces. For all students, really, but especially him. Two suits of armor stood guard on the entrance at all times, a hallmark of another time when the remains of one mage might be destroyed by an enemy.

But the remains of the recently deceased went to another room, where the process of decomposition was initiated by Golems. Only the bones would go below.

Pisces slipped into the room, unseen by the five Golems. He saw them emptying the bags of holding onto the stone slabs. The room was empty save for one dead student. Pisces saw a dead body with too pale skin and realized one of the Selphids must have evacuated it for whatever reason.

Six bodies, then. Pisces sighed softly when he saw the remains of the mages that had been alive not an hour ago.

Illphres, Bastam, Jurix, Ophelia, and Qum. Not all were recognizable. Not all were in one...piece. The Golems bent over their bodies, hands raised. Pisces realized with morbid fascination that they would disassemble the bodies without tools, only brute strength and unyielding fingers.

For a moment, the young man hesitated. He was uncertain, but he stood up as one of the Golems reached down for Bastam's face.

"It is not right. It is not fair. But it must be done. So. *Rise.*"

The bodies jerked and came to life. The Golems paused, not comprehending as two of the six corpses in the room slowly stood up. Pisces felt the magic leave him and staggered. He drank a small potion at his side, cast the spell again. The mana in him burned as it left, but then six corpses were standing.

Not zombies. Not Ghouls, or any of the lesser undead. Burning eyes and flames in empty sockets stared back at Pisces as he looked at the six Liches, mages claimed by undeath to roam the earth.

Liches, yes, but more powerful than their skeletal counterparts. That was just magic used to reanimate long dead bodies. So close to death, these six fallen mages were stronger than Wights, more powerful than common Liches. They were as close to Revenants as he could make them.

The Golems turned towards the undead. They didn't understand what had happened, but they had their orders. One reached for the thing that had been Illphres.

“Fight.”

The Golem fell backwards as a fist struck his chest. Pisces heard the stone crack and saw Illphres’ frail hands moving. She leapt at the Golem, faster than he had ever seen her move. Pisces saw the other Golems fighting now, reacting to the threat.

Too slow. Pisces let the undead knock the Golems down but didn’t bother trying to finish them off. Instead he turned and ran towards the door.

“Follow!”

Wistram was in uproar. Pisces ran down the steps, shouts and screams echoing behind him. The six dead mages followed closely, making no sound as they ran behind him.

He had hoped they wouldn’t be seen as he ran down the corridors, but there were too many students and mages about. But they’d made it. Pisces leapt down the last flight of stairs and gasped for air.

Ahead of him, a tunnel led up towards a gate, guarded by two huge shapes. Armored knight Golems. They blocked the way. Pisces pointed a finger and his undead leapt towards the Golems. They reacted swiftly, raising their swords and shields and charging into the battle.

Pisces ignored both sides. He ran on, using [Flash Step] to evade one of the Golems who tried to cut him as he passed. He had only one goal in mind as he broke the lock on the gate and ran through it.

The catacombs were dark. Ward spells shone in Pisces’ eyes, enchantments designed to prevent the dead from rising by siphoning the mana away. He ran past sarcophagi, alcoves in the wall, coffins and burial urns, searching frantically.

It had to be here. He knew it was here. All the books said—

There. Pisces stumbled into an open corridor and saw the tomb. It was a dark, thick stone slab covering a stone bed. There was only a single glowing line of text, written in an ancient language on the cover. Pisces couldn’t read it, but he knew what it said.

The grave of Archmage Nekhret, one of the true [Archmages] of Wistram. And the only one to be buried in this place. The others had died elsewhere, or left no bodies to bury, or at least no bones.

But Nekhret—Pisces stumbled over to the stone lid and *heaved* at it with all his strength. He couldn't budge the heavy stone. Only when his four remaining undead ran towards him and pushed did the lid fall to the ground with a *crash*.

Pisces knew he had to hurry. He knew he had only minutes before the mages would come, or the Golems to protect this place. But his breath caught as he saw the yellowed bones and the grinning skull of the former archmage. It was just a body. Just a body.

But the bones still glowed with power. Pisces reached out with trembling fingers and then remembered. He took out the small bag of holding he'd stolen from the Golems and reached out to take the bones.

The instant Pisces' hand touched the first bone he felt the world *shift*. He cursed, looked around wildly. Then he realized the magic was coming from the stone coffin itself.

Something was growing out of it. Pisces cried out in terror and shoved the rest of the bones into the bag of holding. He stumbled away, his undead forming a wall around him as something appeared in the air.

A shadow blacker than color pulled itself out of the darkness. From underneath the coffin, more...*things* appeared. They drifted upwards, taking forms that were vaguely like real shapes and at the same time not.

Pure black made up the blade one of the apparitions drew. The blade glowed in the darkness, or rather, made the darkness shine around it. It was the antithesis of light, the shadow in every ray of light.

Slowly, the other summoned creatures drew weapons as well. They were undead, or perhaps something greater. Pisces knew it as he ran, leaving the bodies of the former mages to buy him a second of time. Nekhret's last curse on those who would plunder her tomb.

He should have expected it. But Pisces hadn't thought. He'd only known this was his chance. Now he ran as the apparitions flew after him, screaming with voices that made him throw up as he used [Flash Step] to dash up the stairs.

The undead stormed out of the catacombs as evening drew into night. The students of Wistram and mages heard their screams and turned to fight. Golems and mages alike battled the dark apparitions in the hallways, classrooms, and banquet halls, fighting to save their lives.

Ceria sat in front of the doors leading to the room with the Golems, staring at it. Holding herself back from going in. She wanted to. She wanted to die.

Her master was dead. The other mages were dead. They had died, and the Golems remained. All of them. Each one was intact, each one whole. Ceria couldn't remember—she had seen them lying on the floor—

The memory was too horrible for her mind to actively remember, but Ceria knew she had seen the four Golems before Cognita had pulled her back. Damaged, maybe, but all intact.

They were all still there. And the mages—her friends—Illphres. Were dead.

Ceria wanted to go in that room. She wanted to cast her spells, fight for the few seconds she could. She knew she'd die. But she wanted to prove that Illphres had taught her. Prove she'd been right. Not that she'd done all this for nothing.

It was impossible. Ceria was just dreaming. She'd wake up and—and wake up in her bed. This was just a bad dream.

But it was reality. And although Ceria sat in the corridor for hours, wishing, praying, reality would not change for her.

In the end, it was someone else who made Ceria look up.

“Ah. You're still alive?”

It was a voice Ceria had never heard, not once. She looked up and saw Amerys standing over her. Amerys, the Calm Flower of the Battlefield. One of the King's Seven.

“Go away.”

The woman stared down at Ceria as the half-Elf clutched at her arms, hard enough to bruise her skin. She looked at the doors.

“Well, Illphres is gone now, is she? Too bad. I'll miss her for morning practice. She was always the best at making barriers.”

That casual sentence, the simple acknowledgement of everything Ceria was denying, was too much. She leapt to her feet.

“*Shut up! Shut up!*”

Amerys looked at Ceria, calmly. Not with amusement or scorn, but with something as cold as Illphres' ice in her eyes.

“She's dead.”

“No, she's—”

Ceria couldn't lie. But she didn't want to say it. Amerys studied her and shook her head.

"You know, she told me she was challenging the Golems tonight. She asked me to stop you from killing yourself if she failed."

"She what?"

Ceria stared at Amerys in shock. The woman nodded.

"I would have come earlier, but I figured that you'd either be in that room by now, dead, or wallowing in misery out here."

"But she—she didn't think she'd—she was going to—"

"Change Wistram?"

Amerys snorted softly. Ceria choked. Now tears were falling from her eyes again. Amerys looked back at the doors and sighed softly.

"Perhaps she would have. But Cognita was too strong, wasn't she? If I'd agreed to help, we probably would have died. Then again, maybe not. We'll never know."

"She asked you?"

"Oh yes."

The woman nodded, meeting Ceria's horrified stare.

"I told her no."

"Why? She asked you and you said no? You—you *coward*! If you'd been alive, if you'd helped her—"

Ceria began screaming at Amerys. The woman shook her head, ignoring Ceria's helpless fury.

"It was too risky. If there was a chance of me dying—I told Illphres I wouldn't risk it. I told her to wait, even if it was for another decade, to challenge the Golems with ten times their number if they could. It turns out I was right."

"She was brave! She was a true mage! She and Jurix and Bastam and the others—they had courage. You're supposed to be a famous mage! Why didn't you go? Are you afraid? Are all of the King of Destruction's servants such cowards?"

It was only when Amerys' eyes flashed with fury that Ceria realized who she was talking to. A living legend, the equivalent of any Named Adventurer. Amerys spoke softly, but her voice was filled with controlled... passion.

"Coward? I suppose that's fair. But if I am a coward, it is for my King. Do not misunderstand me, half-Elf. I would go in that room and challenge

the Golems alone if it were not for Flos, my liege.”

“Why?”

The woman turned away from Ceria. When she looked back over her shoulder, her eyes were shining with something similar to the look Ceria had seen in Illphres’ eyes.

“Because he is a king worth being a coward for. Because someday he will return. Make no mistake; someday I will be at his side and we shall challenge the Golems together. We will walk beyond those doors and see for ourselves the heights of magic. But until then I will do all I can to live until the day he calls for me.”

Ceria could say nothing to that. She let the tears run down her eyes as she stared at Amerys. The woman looked away and shook her head.

“Until that day I wait. Hah, it is hard to wait for him for so long. But he is worth it. My lord Flos is...and it isn’t as if there aren’t other dangers to fight in that time.”

“What do you...”

Only now that she was standing, looking at Amerys fully did Ceria see the cut on the woman’s leg. It had gone through her magical robes, cut into her flesh. It was bound tightly with gauze.

“You’re injured.”

“Yes, I am.”

“What happened?”

The Human woman looked at Ceria, not without a trace of pity. But only that. A trace. She pointed to the stairs.

“See for yourself.”

There were less than sixty dead in truth. Less than sixty, but over half as many wounded, some critically. To Ceria, descending the steps and walking through the hallways in numb silence, it was as if the rest of Wistram were a reflection of the death above.

The shades called by Nekhret’s spell had flown through Wistram, not hunting Pisces but setting upon every living being they could find with death and cold fury. The mages and students, unprepared, had fought back, but many of their spells had failed to affect the magical creations.

If it were not for Cognita, if it were not for the Golems and the Archmages and senior mages, Ceria later learned, the casualties would have been far higher. Most of the shadows and phantoms had flown into the banquet hall during dinner, and it was there the battle had been fiercest.

Only sixty had died. But one of those sixty lay on the ground of the banquet hall, amid the overturned tables and trampled food and drink. He had fallen mid-gallop, hands raised, a wand still held tight in one of them.

His face wasn't calm. It was desperate, fierce. Ceria stared down at Calvaron's body and looked into Beatrice's eyes as the Dullahan held him.

"This is your fault."

She told Ceria that, as Mons sat on the ground next to Calvaron. Ceria didn't know what to say.

"What happened?"

"Pisces."

Beatrice turned away. Ceria stared at Calvaron until the Dullahan screamed at her. She wandered away, mumbling to people who asked if she was hurt. At some point she saw Cognita, organizing Golems as they helped tend to the dead.

She saw Pisces just once. He was imprisoned in a cage of magic, guarded by Golems who were there to protect him from the angry mages and students. He stared down at the ground, face pale. He didn't see her.

The trial began that night and lasted well into the next day. The charges were simple. Pisces had stolen the bones of one of the Archmages. He had plundered Archmage Nekhret's tomb and unleashed her spell of retribution on the academy. All the dead were his fault.

The punishment was equally simple. The Council was split, many calling for banishment. Wistram had no jail. The others called for death.

Ceria watched the trial taking place, saw the outrage on the faces of the people around her. But she was numb to it all. News of what had passed above had spread, especially after it came to light how Pisces had reanimated the five fallen mages to break into the catacombs. That was a tragedy on its own, but the mages channeled their shock into anger against Pisces.

Many voices spoke up that night, all for killing Pisces. The mages that held out argued against the death penalty because it would tarnish Wistram's image, because it was wrong in this day and age, because they didn't have the stomach for it. None because they felt sympathy for Pisces.

He kept his head bowed as students and mages hurled accusations against him, screaming.

Beatrice spoke, and then Mons. She didn't plead for Pisces' innocence. She just told the Council she had no idea what was happening, and asked that Pisces be punished. She didn't say what that punishment should be. Montressa stared at Pisces as if he were something she had never seen before.

Ceria was the last one to stand. When she did, the room went quiet. The mages knew she had been Illphres' student. They knew she had been there when they had challenged Cognita and the other Golems, and when the doors had opened. It was Illphres' body and the others Pisces had used to reanimate. They waited for Ceria to attack Pisces. She wondered if they would stop her if she tried to kill him.

There was nothing in Ceria's heart. She looked inside her for her soul, but found it missing. It lay back above, in a corridor frozen in time where the frost clung to the walls. And as Ceria stood before the Council she spoke what was in her heart.

"Ceria Springwalker."

Archmage Feor, the hero of her people, stared down sympathetically at Ceria. She stared back blankly.

"You have known the mage known as Pisces the longest. He has wronged you perhaps most of all. Is there anything you would like to tell the Council regarding his fate?"

Ceria stared around at the august assembly of faces staring down at her. She nodded slowly. When she spoke, her voice was quiet, but magnified by the spell so it filled the room.

"There is something. If my master—if Illphres knew what Pisces had done with her body...she would have laughed. She would have laughed, and she wouldn't have cared at all."

The room fell silent. The mages murmuring to each other grew quiet as Ceria continued.

"Pisces? I know him. He was my friend. Once. I hate him for what he did to my master—for what he did to the others. I hate him so much I think I might kill him. But I hate the rest of you even more."

She looked around the room, eyes burning.

"You knew they were going to challenge the Golems. You knew. They asked you—each one of you to join them. You all said no. So they had to go

by themselves, only five of them. If there had been six, or ten—they might have lived. But they went alone, because the rest of you are cowards.”

Shock. Anger. It was all the same to Ceria. She stared around the room and addressed the Council of Wistram to their faces, called them what they were.

“You are all cowards. Fearful, small people, living in the shadow of the Golems. You won’t ever find true magic, not here. Not while Cognita and the Golems are the true rulers of this place. I’m leaving—I won’t stay here, hiding from the truth. So long as the Golems live, there are no true mages in Wistram. None, except for the dead.”

She turned and walked away. Voices shouted after her, but Ceria was deaf. She sat down and saw the Council restore order, begin to vote.

One more person strode into the room, unannounced. But she brought silence with her.

Cognita. She stood in front of the Council, the death of mages on her hands yet no trace of it marring her smooth exterior. Perfect, wrought of stone. Immortal. And she spoke for Pisces.

“I would ask you not to vote to execute this young student.”

“Why?”

The answer came from Feor. Ceria looked at him, and saw a trace of that fear in his eyes. In all the mages’ eyes. They looked at Cognita and saw something they could not surpass, did not dare to challenge. She addressed them calmly, her voice booming throughout the room unaided.

“Because it would be unjust. There have been other mages whose failed experiments have killed far more. There have been other students here who have committed greater crimes and been expelled for it. The death sentence has never been passed down for a true mistake made by a student. I argue for exile, not death. If you pass judgment, let it be for what he has done, not what he is. Necromancy is not a sin.”

Feor stared hard at Cognita.

“And what will you do if we vote to kill him?”

She replied calmly.

“I will do nothing. My role is to protect and serve Wistram and those who live within. But if you do decide to execute him, I will expect you to kill every student who errs thusly from now on.”

The mages murmured as she left. Pisces raised his head to stare after her. He saw Ceria staring at him and looked away.

In the end, the Council argued for hours, but voted. It was close, but those who voted for exile were slightly more numerous than those who voted for death. Feor stood on the podium, staring down at Pisces with contempt.

“For your crimes, we exile you. You will never set foot on Wistram’s shores again, under penalty of death. And this shall be spread across the world—no true mage of Wistram shall treat with you, Pisces.”

The young man didn’t look up. Feor’s gaze turned to Ceria’s and softened.

“As for you, Ceria Springwalker. You must leave as well. Pack your belongings. You will leave Wistram with the next ship.”

A few things happened in between the time Ceria spent wandering Wistram and the day she left. The half-Elf was attacked by Beatrice for defending Pisces as the Dullahan saw it, only saved by Mons. She was an exile among the other mages, none of whom spoke to her.

But one mage thought of her, or rather, her master. Amerys stood in front of the door that was still covered with frost and tried the handle. It didn’t work.

In the end Amerys gave up on waiting for a key to be brought and blasted the door open. The thunderous sound drew other students to her room. They backed away when they saw her exit the room, holding something in her hands.

“Here. Give this to Ceria Springwalker.”

“Me?”

“Do it. Or I will find out.”

Amerys thrust the ice-blue spellbook into the hands of one of the students in the crowd. He recoiled, but after she glared at him, took the book with trembling hands. Amerys strode away without a backwards glance.

The unfortunate Drake held the book in his hands, hesitating. He started down the corridor, but never got to Ceria’s room.

A young man stopped him in the hallway with some of his friends. The Drake and he argued. Gold was offered, then secrets. In the end the book was traded and it went with the young man.

Charles de Trevalier walked through Wistram, upwards, onto a balcony where Ceria had sat with Illphres once before. He stood on the edge over the open, looking down into the sea. Then he let the book drop down into the sea.

It splashed when it hit the water, and Charles saw the book freeze the ocean around it. It disappeared beneath the waves, encased in ice that refused to float or melt.

He turned around, smiling, and saw the Dullahan staring at him. Charles' smile disappeared, but Beatrice said nothing. She turned and walked away.

Two days later, Ceria found herself standing in the entrance hall, waiting. The ship was here at last, ready to take them to Izril. It wasn't her choice. This was the first ship and so she had to be aboard it.

Someone else stood in the entrance hall, far away from her. Pisces kept his head down as he clutched the few things to his name. A spellbook, and a small bag. Ceria stared at him but he didn't raise his head.

No one had come to see her off. Montressa had stopped by her room. Beatrice had not. Ceria had seen a few other students as well, but the rest of the mages had avoided her as well as Pisces.

This was it. Ceria stared numbly at the doors and realized it was time. She was leaving Wistram, a failure. With nothing to her name but a few coins and memories.

"Hold."

The word caught Ceria as she started towards the doors. It came from a tall figure, Cognita. She strode towards Ceria and stopped before the young half-elf. Ceria stared up blankly. Cognita inclined her head.

"Ceria Springwalker. I regret the death of Illphres and the other mages."

"Do you really?"

Ceria said it numbly. Cognita nodded.

"I do. But I was created to protect and so I shall."

"In that case, I hate you. I'll hate you forever and I think you're a slave. You don't have will. You're just a thing that pretends to sometimes be alive."

"That is your choice."

Cognita accepted Ceria's statement without a hint of displeasure. She bent down to Ceria. Her eyes were intent on the half-Elf's face.

"But I see in you something worthy. So I ask that you accept what comes next, and know that it is a sign of respect, not mockery."

"What?"

Cognita didn't answer. She strode towards the doors and threw them open. Ceria and Pisces shielded their faces from the sun's glare.

"Step forwards, you two. Side by side."

Unwillingly, Ceria did so. She stared at Pisces and he looked down. Cognita looked at both students and raised her voice.

Her words echoed throughout Wistram. They weren't loud, not a shout, but they travelled through the corridors, into rooms, making mages stand up and go to the windows. Those that were already watching were joined by other mages as Cognita spoke to the academy.

"Today Wistram will see two students depart from its shores. These two mages leave, one exiled, the other in contempt. They leave as failures by the reckoning of the Council. But the Golems of Wistram disagree."

She swept an arm out. Shading her eyes, Ceria heard Pieces draw in his breath. She looked out, down the winding stone staircase that led to the stone harbor and gasped.

Golems stood on the staircase. Hundreds of Golems. Stone ones carved to look like Humans or other races, suits of animated armor, creations Ceria had only seen once or twice. A Golem made of pure emerald stood next to one that seemed to be made of the wind itself. It stood next to a being of wood with moss and flowers growing out of its body. It held a sword out, saluting the air.

Cognita's voice rang out again, and Ceria saw students and mages appearing on the stairwells and bridges above the entrance hall. They stared down at her as the Golem kept speaking, stared at her and Pisces.

"I am Cognita, greatest of Archmage Zelkyr's creations. Though I am no mage, I hold his authority, which supersedes all others so long as I remain. Thus, it is within my power to graduate you two on this day. Ceria Springwalker, Pisces, you have shown the qualities of a true mage of Wistram, both of you. Neither of you will fall behind any other mage nor disgrace Wistram's name. I hereby name both of you full mages of the academy."

Ceria stared up at the Golem, barely able to comprehend what was happening. Pisces' face was pale as he looked up at the Golem. Cognita smiled slightly, and motioned them forwards.

It was a dream. Ceria slowly began walking down the steps, Pisces at her side. She looked at the rows of impassive Golem faces, and saw how they were turned towards her. Watching her. As if they were alive.

"Golems of Wistram! Salute these young mages as they go forth into the world! Though they may leave these shores, they pass from here not as students, but as true mages!"

Step by step, the two descended. Ceria's ears were roaring, and she saw the ship ahead of her, drawing closer. She stopped with Pisces only once and looked back towards the citadel. The doors were thrown open and a tall woman made of stone stood there. She raised her hand and her voice carried clearly to the two down below.

"Go, Ceria Springwalker and Pisces. Walk proudly as true mages of Wistram."

Then she turned and the Golems began to file back into the academy or walked into the sea. Ceria turned and caught Pisces' eye for a brief moment. Then she turned and boarded the ship and sailed away from Wistram.

This is how the story ended. Ceria and Pisces took the ship for several days to Izril, seldom speaking, and not at all to each other. For their part, the [Captain] and [Sailors] treated the two mages with great respect. They had seen the Golems lining the stairs for the two mages—they were surely some of Wistram's best.

The irony was not lost on Ceria, but she could only think about Illphres, about Calvaron, and felt the emptiness in her vanishing day by day. Not because she wanted to feel again, but because life was going on. It was as if she left that part of her with Wistram.

She knocked on Pisces' door on the last day of their voyage, when land had been spotted. He let her in and she sat on a chair while he sat on the bed.

"I'm sorry."

He said that at last, looking up at her. Ceria just stared back until he looked down again. There was nothing he could say, and nothing she

wanted to hear. She eventually said what was on her mind.

“Once we reach the shore, we’ll part ways. I never want to see your face again, understand?”

“Yes.”

They heard sailors calling out overhead, guiding the ship in to dock. Pisces shifted, wiped at his eyes. Ceria saw tears. She had none herself.

“It truly—it truly was a wonderful place, wasn’t it?”

She looked at him. Pisces was crying.

“It was just like my dream at first. It was everything I had hoped for. It was the place where I wanted to be forever. It was worth waiting for. Worth giving everything up for.”

Slowly, Ceria nodded. She stared past Pisces, seeing friends and memory, stone corridors, magic and sadness and happiness in the moment before she blinked. Then she did and it was gone.

“It really was.”

They sat in silence as the rocking ship slowed and they felt it stop. Ceria stood up and looked down at Pisces.

“Goodbye.”

She walked away, carrying the rucksack filled with the few things she had to her name. Ceria walked away from the ship that had taken her from her hopes and dreams, away from the young man who had once been her best friend.

But never would Ceria forget. In her dark dreams, in the moments when she sat around campfires with the new friends she made, in the days spent walking, footsore and tired, searching for a place to rest, she’d always think back on it.

An isle in the sea. A citadel of dark stone, standing in a bubble of calm while storms raged around it. Hallways full of magic, impassive stone golems, students and mages of every race. A place of wonder, of magic.

The place where mages gather. The home of sorcery.

Wistram.

The half-Elf walked away, and was lost in the night. And after a moment, the young man, the necromancer, stepped off the ship. He looked back once, and then he was gone too.

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The half-Elf walked off into the darkness, leaving Wistram behind. After a moment, Pisces stepped off the ship as well. He looked back towards the ocean where Wistram could no longer be seen, but where he knew it lay. Then he turned and was gone too.

The story ended. Ceria looked up from the depths of her mug and saw two watery eyes staring back at her. She blinked and leaned back a bit. There was a bit of snot mixed with the tears.

“Um, Erin? Are you okay?”

“I’m fine! I’m fine, it’s just—”

Erin reached for a handkerchief and wiped at her eyes. She had another one for her nose. Three, actually.

“And you never went back? Ever? You never heard from any of your friends, or—or sent a letter?”

“Never.”

Ceria shook her head, feeling the small gap in her heart aching a bit. But it was only a small rift, a faded scar that time had patched over. It had been a long time since she’d dared think about the past, but it had helped to tell someone at last.

“And so that Golem—Cognita is still in Wistram? And your friend Beatrice is all alone, and Montressa too? That’s so...*sad*.”

Erin blew her nose again and Ceria smiled crookedly. It wasn’t really a smile.

“That’s life. I wouldn’t be surprised if Montressa is a fully-fledged mage by now and far more experienced than both me and Pisces combined. But I don’t know. I never heard from them.”

“But it’s not fair! You weren’t the one who killed Calvaron! And neither was Pisces! I mean, it was his fault, but he couldn’t have known about the trap spell! And it sounds like the other mages treated him horribly!”

“He did practice necromancy.”

“Yeah, but still—he only became a jerk after everyone started being a jerk to him, right? I understand so much more about him now!”

“I—wouldn’t take all of what I said to heart, Erin. Pisces did change thanks to how people treated him later on, but he was always a necromancer. He always kept secrets. Even from me.”

“I get it. But it’s still so tragic. It hurts just to hear it.”

Erin put down the soggy handkerchief and Ceria drank down the last dregs in her mug. Around them, a few late-night drinkers were being shepherded out of the inn by Maran, but Erin and Ceria were safe at their table in the corner. After all, Erin practically ran the inn even when Miss Agnes was around and Ceria didn’t have anywhere to be.

Of course, many miles away a lonely cart was rumbling down the road where three other adventurers were probably trying to sleep, but Ceria didn’t have to join them. Not tonight.

It had been Pisces’ idea. Fed up by sleeping on the wagon each night, despite the hand-delivered food and copious amounts of blankets and pillows, the mage had demanded one member of the group be allowed to sleep in the Frenzied Hare each night.

Ksmvr hadn’t cared, but Ceria and Yvlon weren’t entirely immune to the allure of the idea themselves. So the three of them had drawn straws to see who would go back the first night.

It had been Ceria who’d won the straw pick. She’d come back and been feasted by Erin while she watched a new play—something about a girl with a thick accent learning to speak correctly—being put on.

But that wasn’t the important part of the night. The important part had come when Erin sat with Ceria and they had talked about the incredible mage they’d met. Ceria had asked Erin how she knew him, or rather how Ryoka knew him, and somehow that conversation had led back to the past.

To the past, and a story Ceria had never told anyone. How she and Pisces had first met, how they had become friends—

And how they had lost that and left Wistram. Now, in the quietest hour of the day, just past midnight, Ceria listened to Erin snuffling.

“It’s history now. If I could go back I’d do everything differently. But time travel is one of the things even the greatest of mages can’t do. My master, Illphres, died in the academy. I left because all that I respected and aspired towards died with her.”

“You didn’t want to stay? Even though…”

“Maybe.”

Ceria stared into the embers of the fire.

“Yes. I did. I regretted saying what I did to the Council. But—I still left because of what she said before she challenged Cognita.”

“What?”

The half-Elf shrugged, uncomfortably.

“It was just a comment. If she had been an adventurer, perhaps she would have known the danger she was walking into. That’s...one of the reasons I decided to become an adventurer. Illphres was far more powerful than most mages, far more powerful than I can dream of right now. But she died because she wasn’t used to fighting, not like adventurers are. We fight dirty and learn to run away. She and the other mages were proud. Too proud. I see that now.”

“But they sounded amazing.”

A sigh escaped Ceria’s lips.

“They were. I wish you could have met them.”

“But it sounds like Pisces was incredible too, wasn’t he? Before people knew he was a [Necromancer]—they really liked him, didn’t they?”

“Yes. They did.”

“I can’t really imagine that.”

Something like a laugh escaped Ceria’s lips. She turned to Erin, smiling in the dim light.

“It is hard to see, isn’t it? But just imagine Pisces without the sneer. Without any rude comments or—or his dirty robes. He is a genius at magic and Cognita herself acknowledged his skill. If we hadn’t fought those pirates at sea, if he had never been found out, he might be a powerful mage rising higher in Wistram right now.”

“Wow.”

More silence. Ceria saw the light in the room dim further, until Erin was just a dark silhouette in front of her. She could have cast a spell to light up the room, but this suited their conversation. After a while, she spoke out loud, confessing one last thing to Erin.

“That day, I think Cognita was speaking to Pisces, not me. He was the one who truly deserved to graduate from Wistram like that. I—I’m just a dropout. A failure. But I used the name of Wistram because it meant I could get work and it opened doors for me.”

“You’re not.”

Ceria shook her head.

“I am. A true accredited Wistram mage is a rare thing, with far more experience and a deeper understanding of magic. What that old mage said—you saw him trash us in moments. Regardless of whether the quality of mages has declined since Archmage Zelkyr, we’re still far below that standard. I am.”

Something touched Ceria’s hand. She jerked, but it was Erin’s hand. The girl squeezed Ceria’s hand gently. Her good hand.

“I don’t think you’re a failure. You went into Albez, didn’t you? And you came out.”

“Huh. I guess we did.”

Ceria smiled as the last light disappeared. She couldn’t see Erin’s face, but she knew the other girl was smiling too.

The next day, Erin treated Ceria to a huge breakfast. Not the usual kind either—she’d made spiced porridge seasoned with a bit of fruit to go with mulled wine. It was hot, filling, and it made Pisces stop complaining when they brought it to the cart to be eaten on the road.

Erin sat next to Ceria as they ate from bowls on the bouncing wagon. Pisces and Yylon looked cold but awake and Ksmvr seemed happy to wolf down the gluten-rich food with no side effects.

“I appreciate the effects of this magical charm. I wonder if it may be duplicated?”

“Probably. It’s such a low-grade enchantment even Springwalker could do it.”

Pisces remarked testily and got a kick and a glare for it. He rubbed his leg as he continued.

“It is possible, but why would you need a second artifact, Ksmvr? My understanding is that you are exiled from your Hive. Unless you have plans to join one of the Antinium Hives in the south?”

Ksmvr went very still as Ceria glared at Pisces. He shrugged insolently. At last, the Antinium spoke quietly.

“It is true that I have been removed from my position due to my incompetence. But I would never join another Hive. My true place—and my Queen—is in Liscor. I hope to return some day, bringing gifts such as

this charm to prove my worth. But until I can prove myself useful, I will adventure with you. If I may.”

Ceria nodded.

“Of course, Ksmvr. You’re a valuable member of The Horns of Hammerad.”

“And far better company than Pisces.”

“Hah. While Ksmvr’s presence may be more appealing, may I remind you that my abilities are unique within this group? No one can provide the unique skills and insights that I have at my—”

“Shut up, Pisces.”

“Yeah, shut up, Pisces! You were nicer back when you were in Wistram.”

“What?”

Pisces blinked. He stared at Erin as she frowned at him. Ceria sighed. She didn’t quite meet Pisces’ eyes.

“I told her about our time in Wistram last night.”

“Oh.”

Ksmvr’s head swiveled from Pisces to Ceria as the young man blinked at Ceria and then went red. The Antinium opened his mandibles but Yvlon nudged him.

“Why did you nudge me, Comrade Yv—”

She sighed, pulled him over and whispered into Ksmvr’s earhole while Pisces cleared his throat a few times.

“Ah, Ceria told you about our shared history?”

“She did. She said you were a really nice guy, once. What happened?”

Pisces’ eyes flashed.

“Well, if she told you the truth, you would know that it was because of the unfounded prejudice and intolerance—”

“Because other people were jerks to you. I get it. But you still became sort of a jerk yourself, you know.”

Pisces had nothing to say to that. He just looked at Ceria, angrily, as if she’d given away a precious secret. She stared silently at him, meeting his eyes, until he remembered and looked down. Remembering the past made it harder to sit across from Pisces so easily for Ceria, though she’d made her peace with it all.

Erin glanced between the two, seeing the tension. She raised her voice.

“Um. I do have a few questions. I didn’t ask last night Ceria, but...you know, I think you made some of your story up.”

Ceria frowned at Erin.

“I did not.”

“I dunno...Pisces, you were there. Did Ceria’s master—Illphres—did she *really* destroy six ships all by herself? And did you and Ceria really fight two Trolls during the entrance exams?”

Pisces’ eyes flicked to Ceria. The half-Elf colored and looked over the wagon’s side.

“I...may have exaggerated some details.”

“Clearly. However, Miss...Erin, I would impress on you one thing. If, that is, Ceria told you how it ended?”

Pisces grew serious. He looked at Ceria as if to ask her what she’d told her. She raised her hand and a fiery creature drew a simple message in the air, in the code only they could read.

Everything.

“—Mages aside. Pirates aside. The Sea Serpent—assuming Springwalker told you there was only one? Yes, that might be exaggerated. But there is no description that can truly convey the power of Wistram’s true rulers. The Golems. Cognita was, and remains, the most powerful being I have ever encountered in the world.”

The wagon grew silent as everyone thought of that. Erin looked back down the frozen road.

“Even that crazy old man with the iPhone?”

“Well, we saw very little of his power. But...yes. The quality of his magic is meaningless against the Golems of Archmage Zelkyr. They were built for war. Mages may cast spells of incredible destruction, but few are suited to combat.”

He met Ceria’s gaze and then looked away again. After another second, Erin piped up.

“You took the bones of the [Archmage], didn’t you? You put them in Toren.”

Yvlon’s head snapped up. Ceria winced, and Pisces drew in his breath sharply.

“I did.”

“Does that mean he was as powerful as an [Archmage]?”

“Hardly. And I didn’t use many bones. I only used four.”

“Four?”

Ceria stared at Pisces. He nodded fractionally.

“Four. I carved the spell into the bones, to restore the form I gave Toren no matter how badly he might be broken. They are...what makes him unique. But they consume too much mana for him to survive without a source.”

“I get it.”

Erin sighed. She sat back down in the cart and pulled a blanket over herself. She stared at the grey sky as no one said anything for several minutes.

“You sounded really cool, you know.”

“Excuse me?”

“You. Ceria told me about how you used to duel people, and cast magic. You sounded cool.”

Pisces opened his mouth. He closed it, swallowed, opened it again, and closed it once more. He closed his eyes. Then he spoke quietly.

“Thank you.”

“You’re welcome.”

The cart rumbled onwards, taking the Horns of Hammerad down the road. Occasionally they passed by wagons and called out greetings or asked about dangers on the road. But the adventurers just sat in silence, mainly, along with Termin who was used to just having the company of his own head.

It was a cold day, but they were warm enough. And so Ceria and Pisces sat on opposite sides of the wagon and remembered.

When the sun hit midday, the cart stopped to let the horses rest for a while.

“Even with a Skill they need a break, if only to eat.”

Termin explained as Erin happily patted one of the horses, Erma, on the head and she chewed her oats. Fox was busy trying to eat the food Erin had brought—warm bread and a spicy dip as a snack with cold meat and cheese for toppings.

“Shoo! You damn horse.”

Pisces waved it away as Ksmvr sliced cheese, cutting with little regard for the sharp blade of his dagger. Fox wandered away and Erin happily accepted a sandwich from Ceria before nearly dropping it.

“It’s *hot!*”

“Really? Sorry. I tried to tone down the heating spell, but it’s hard when one hand’s...”

Ceria waved her skeletal hand. Erin shook her head as she juggled the hot sandwich.

“No, it’s just that I wasn’t expecting it. Magic is really useful, isn’t it?”

“Best thing on a road.”

Yvlon smiled as she accepted a second sandwich from Ceria. She peered at Ceria’s hands as the half-Elf warmed another sandwich for Termin, trying not to scorch the bread.

“I thought you were a specialist at ice-magic, Ceria. Is it hard to cast flame spells?”

“I used to be quite good at earth and fire magic. It’s my master who taught me a bunch of ice spells.”

Ceria shrugged as she tossed Termin a sandwich. He bowed slightly to her and she grinned and waved a hand in reply.

“I have a few Skills that improve my ice magic, but it’s not like I can’t cast any spell I learn, Yvlon.”

“I see. Magic’s a mystery to me, so I wondered.”

“You never tried to learn?”

Ceria sat with Yvlon on the wagon, the only non-snowy surface, as Erin and Termin clambered on top as well. Yvlon shook her head.

“Not my thing. I had a tutor of course—most rich families have tutors who teach their kids all sorts of skills and find what they might be good at. I couldn’t figure out how to cast [Light] and neither could my older brother or my sister. Swinging a sword works well enough for me.”

“But it’s *magic*. If I could learn it, I’d be so thrilled!”

Erin sighed as she chewed her warm food. There was something special about eating in the cold and on the road, she decided. It gave her food... character. Then she remembered something else and slapped her head.

“I forgot! I was going to give you all some of my Corusdeer horn soup! My blue soup!”

The others eyed Erin.

“Your what?”

“Hang on! I’ll show you!”

Erin opened the door lying on the back of the wagon and crawled through it into Octavia’s shop. One of the [Alchemist’s] customers had a very nasty scare when he saw Erin crawling into the shop—from his perspective, it looked like Erin was crawling out of the sky, down through the doorway. But in a few seconds she had some of the soup she’d kept in a glass jar and was showing it triumphantly to the others.

Ceria and Yvlon stared hard at the soup adhering to the walls of the glass. It certainly looked blue, but that wasn’t a good thing. Blueberries were edible, and so was blue cheese, but there was something about blue soup that made it look particularly nasty.

The wagon driver shook his head the instant Erin uncorked the bottle and offered the soup around. All the ingredients had become a gelatinous mess from sitting in the bottle for so long, and the fact that it was still steaming didn’t make it any more appealing.

“I’m not eating that.”

“Aw, come on!”

Erin tried to get him to take a bite, then Yvlon. At last Ceria tried it, but only after Erin had taken a few bites and not immediately thrown up.

“It’s...dead gods, it’s not bad, Erin, but it doesn’t taste that great either.”

Ceria mumbled around the mouthful before she swallowed. The soup was hot going down, and that too felt wrong. But after a few moments, the half-Elf blinked and gasped.

“It’s *hot!*”

“See?”

Erin beamed around as the others stared at Ceria. The half-Elf’s cheeks had flushed and she was starting to sweat.

“It’s way too hot. Erin, is that soup magical? I have cold protection spells on—I feel like I’m in an oven!”

“Oops. Sorry.”

Ceria shook her head as she examined the soup with renewed interest.

“You made magical soup? I can’t believe it.”

“It’s great! And I think I can make an actual dish next time, not just soup. But this stuff is going to be a huge hit—you can drink it and you won’t feel the cold even if you’re naked!”

“Tested it out, have you?”

Yvlon sighed but took a few bites. Termin did too, and in a few moments everyone was walking around and shedding clothes, standing in the snow and remarking at the way it melted on their bare skin.

“You’ll make a fortune off it—assuming you can sell a lot before the winter ends. Is it expensive?”

“Not too much. But I’ve got other soups and stuff as well! Funny—I always have to make it into a soup first. After that I can figure out how to combine stuff, but soup is easiest to experiment with.”

Erin offered Pisces the last bit of the blue soup. He declined, letting Ksmvr consume the rest of the enchanted food.

“Enchanted cooking is a rarity even in Wistram. I suspect your products will do very well, especially given the difficulty in reproducing a recipe such as this from taste alone.”

The innkeeper smiled wickedly.

“Yeah. No one’s stealing *this* recipe.”

“I feel like I could lie about in the snow all day. But I suppose I’ll settle for a nice breeze while riding. Time to be off!”

Termin clambered aboard the driver’s seat and called to the others. Erin, Ceria, and Yvlon got on top, but Pisces declined.

“I will walk.”

Everyone stared. Yvlon, Ceria, and Ksmvr had all walked to stretch out, but up till this moment Pisces had refused to expend one bit of energy more than necessary. Termin just shrugged and shook the reins lightly.

“Your choice. Just don’t fall behind, necromancer.”

Erin laughed. Erma and Fox began pulling the wagon, faster than a walk but so slowly that Pisces would be able to catch up quickly.

But the mage didn’t immediately walk after the wagon. Instead, he stayed where he was. Sitting on the wagon back, Ceria frowned. She was about to call back at him when Pisces took one step.

Snow whirled. It flew up into the air in a gust, following the mage. He blurred forwards—too fast to really be called movement at all—and appeared right next to the back of the wagon.

Erin gasped.

“[Flash Step]! That’s the spell, right?”

“It is.”

Ceria watched as Pisces stood still next to the wagon, letting it continue onwards for about five seconds. Then he took a step and appeared next to it

in a moment. He looked up, and his eyes met Ceria's. Both mages looked away.

From her seat, Yvlon frowned at Pisces before looking at Ceria.

"I saw Pisces using that spell in the ruins and in the battle with that old mage. I didn't know there was a spell like it until now. It looks incredibly useful. Do you know it?"

Ceria shook her head.

"It was one of his specialties. It's a good spell for movement, but very hard to use. One bad step and you can break your foot or your toes."

"Ah."

Pisces continued to follow the wagon. At first Erin kept staring at him, gasping a bit as he blinked forwards with each step, but quite soon she grew tired of the spectacle. Ceria didn't, though. She knew what Pisces was doing.

He was training.

With each step, Pisces kept pace with the wagon. It was slow, monotonous, and, Ceria knew, had to be mentally draining. But the fact that Pisces could keep performing the spell over and over was a sign of the skill she'd told Erin about.

What was amazing was the accuracy. At first it was off—Pisces would teleport too far ahead and spook the horses, or end up a few feet behind the wagon—but as time went on he eventually started appearing right at the back of the wagon, each and every time.

That was unusual, and Ceria knew both Yvlon and Ksmvr could tell how impressive that feat was. The wagon didn't move at a uniform pace and the road wasn't always straight. Pisces had to calculate how far to step at a distance in order to land precisely where he wanted to go.

After a while, Pisces added to the exercise. He drew his rapier from its sheathe and walked slowly forwards with it on the balls of his feet. Each time he stepped now, it was into a thrust, as if he were stabbing an opponent in the heart.

Now Pisces would step forwards into a slow lunge, fully extending his back leg while all the weight rested on the front. He kept his arm still as he held the rapier extended as far as he could go. Pisces slowly stepped out of the lunge, blurred forwards and moved into it again.

Slowly. Ceria could see his arms shaking the fourth time he did it, and he began to sweat despite not having had any of Erin's soup.

After thirty minutes Pisces had to stop. He could barely raise his arms, despite alternating them while lifting the rapier. He collapsed onto the back of the wagon, panting as he pulled a blanket over to wipe his forehead.

“Wow. That looked really hard.”

Erin offered Pisces a pillow and he sank his head onto it, exhausted. He nodded, too tired for sarcasm.

“I am out of shape. It has been a long, long time since I last...”

“Not bad. You have excellent form.”

Yvlon handed Pisces a water flask. She looked at him with a touch of respect. He nodded wordlessly as he drank deeply from it.

“It is a shame the Antinium cannot learn magic. I believe I would benefit greatly from mastering such a spell.”

Ksmvr remarked as he stared at Pisces’ rapier. Ceria shook her head and saw Yvlon and Termin both doing it as well. For all she liked Ksmvr as a person, the thought of thousands of Antinium using [Flash Step]—or a basic spell like [Stone Dart]—was a nightmare.

Pisces shook his head as he handed the water flask back to Yvlon.

“Your species has a distinct absence of any kind of magical affinity, Ksmvr.”

The Antinium nodded calmly.

“Yes. This has been well observed and is a deliberate factor of our creation. Moreover, since the Antinium do not level greatly, magic has not been seen as a viable field to explore for our species.”

“Good. The last thing Wistram needs is Antinium mages running around.”

“I don’t know. I suppose seeing a few Antinium sitting in Rievan’s class would be quite amusing, don’t you?”

Pisces glanced sideways at Ceria. She couldn’t help but grin.

After a few hours Termin called out to the half-dozing adventurers and Erin sitting in the back of the wagon.

“There’s the city. I heard it was abandoned and then retaken. Should we go around, do you think?”

“What city? Oh—”

Erin gasped as she stood up on the wagon. Ceria reached to steady her, but then stopped as well. Yvlon sighed softly as she spotted the distant buildings. Familiar, and yet alien now.

“Esthelm.”

It was more of a whisper. Erin peered at the walls, clearly damaged from a distance, and the way many buildings were only partly standing.

“Whoa. It looks messed up.”

“Well? Go around or go to it?”

“I heard my brother had helped retake the city. I’d like to ask about him, if we can.”

Yvlon turned to the others. Ceria nodded.

“To the city then, Mister Termin. We can probably rest there for the night.”

“So long as they don’t look too hungry. The last thing I need is a bunch of starving folk trying to eat Erma and Fox...”

Termin grumbled as he drove them onwards. The closer they got, the more Erin could see the damage that had been done to Esthelm. The damage, and just as notably, the repairs.

“Looks like they’ve patched up the wall pretty well. And it’s manned.”

Ceria noted the Humans standing on the battlements with bows. Their wagon had already been spotted and she could tell people were eying her back as well. Esthelm was vigilant after two Goblin attacks it seemed.

“Not only that. Look—they’re reinforcing it.”

Yvlon pointed down the wall, where work was clearly being done to expand the fortifications and add onto them. Pisces sighed as he stared at the burnt and ruined buildings.

“I suppose we won’t be resting in luxury here. It might be best to camp outside of the city if all the buildings are in such a state of disarray.”

“We’ll see when we get in. But at least we can eat at Erin’s inn.”

“True! And we can stay there if Termin finds a place to put his horses for the night.”

“Oh no.”

The wagon driver crossed his arms firmly.

“I won’t sleep anywhere away from Erma and Fox. They get agitated if I’m not close by and I won’t risk them being stolen. One of you’s got to stay here at least.”

“I volunteer.”

“Good for you, Ksmvr.”

“Thanks, Ksm!”

“You are a valuable member of the team. Exceptionally useful, I must say.”

Ksmvr nodded modestly as the others thanked him warmly.

“I volunteered for the position because I believed I was most suitable for the job. Guard detail is a position of merit, but I will understand if anyone wishes to trade places with me.”

Soon, the wagon was in hailing distance of the walls. Termin shouted up at the people shouting at him and after much shouting and arm waving, the gates were opened and the wagon rolled in.

Yvlon spoke to the others before they got out of the cart. She’d tugged a cloak around her head, covering up her bright hair and covering her face.

“When we talk to people, let’s just mention we’re adventurers passing through on guard duty. If we can avoid using my name—or our group’s name—I’d appreciate it.”

“Why? Is it because of your brother? Ylawes?”

Ceria frowned at Yvlon. The young woman nodded, looking unhappy.

“I’d prefer not to meet him at the moment if we can. He could be troublesome.”

“Define troublesome, if you please. Dangerous?”

Yvlon shook her head, frowning at Pisces.

“No. He’s not a threat—so long as he doesn’t meet Ksmvr for the first time alone I guess. But he’s...”

Erin nodded.

“I understand. Lips sealed, right everyone?”

They looked at her. She sighed, exasperated.

“Don’t you get it? This Ylawes guy. He might be a nice guy and all, but he’s still her older brother.”

“So?”

“So he’s going to be an *older brother*.”

“Oh.”

Ceria and Pisces nodded in understanding, despite Ceria not having any siblings to speak of. Ksmvr just tilted his head.

“I do not understand. Pisces, please explain—”

“So this is Esthelm.”

Erin stared around at the ruined buildings, at the people in dirty clothes, helping to lift timber, board up buildings, repair, dismantle, clear rubble and make weapons. There were men and women and children helping to fletch arrows amid the confusion, and more still coming in with game they’d hunted.

“It’s a mess.”

Yvlon kept her voice low as she glanced with sympathy at the citizens. Many looked hungry, but none looked as if they were starving. If they had, Erin would have given them what she could, or gone to Celum for food, but the people here were...strange.

They were ragged yes, hungry, yes, and dirty. But they weren’t beaten. They worked together with purpose, helping to rebuild their city as the wagon trundled into the center of the city.

A man bustled up to the wagon with a few armed citizens following them. Ceria was worried how they’d react when they saw Ksmvr, but the man in charge—some former [Soldier] by the look of him, wearing thick leather armor—didn’t blink more than once.

“Adventurers? Are you escorting the wagon?”

“That’s right. Is the city...safe?”

Termin asked nervously. The men were inspecting the wagon, staring at the single door on the back of the wagon and the blankets and pillows in some confusion. The man in charge nodded.

“That’s right. We fought off the last Goblin army that attacked this place and we’re not going to let a third one get past our walls again. We’re surviving, but we need supplies. We’ve asked for help from the other cities, but Celum, Wales, Remendia...they’re all claiming the roads are unsafe to send supplies down. So until we can get help we’re on our own.”

“Oh. Is it bad?”

The soldier turned his attention to Erin. She was staring at some children hauling nails in a bucket to some carpenters. He shook his head.

“Not bad, Miss. But I’m afraid that we might have to confiscate your wagon’s cargo if you’ve got anything we can use. We’re in dire need of food, blankets—”

“There’s nothing in here, Umbral!”

One of the men shouted to the man in charge. He frowned and looked at the empty back of the wagon.

“You don’t have *any* food or supplies? Where’s your cargo?”

“It’s her.”

Ceria pointed to Erin and the young woman waved.

“We’re escorting her to Liscor. She’s an innkeeper, so she doesn’t have much coin. It’s a favor—”

“But we do have food! I can get some—and you can have all the blankets and pillows! I’ll get more as well!”

Out of the corner of her eye, Ceria saw Erin pointing at the door and hoped that Umbral didn’t understand what Erin was saying. Fortunately, the man just looked confused. He tried to stop Erin when she started handing pillows and blankets down.

“We wouldn’t want to take your only supplies, Miss. We’re not robbers—we’ll pay a fair price—”

“Take it, please!”

“A place to sleep would be payment enough, sir.”

Ceria interrupted Erin and she saw Yvlon pull Erin back and whisper to her. The blankets and pillows disappeared fast, and Umbral directed them to some of the sturdier buildings in the city.

“Don’t worry about your horses, or your wagon. I’ll see to it that no one tries to make off with either. You can rest assured—we’re past thievery and attacking each other here.”

He waved them on. Ceria sat back with a sigh as Erin drooped into the wagon seat beside her.

“I can’t give them clothing and food and stuff? But they need it!”

“If they knew we had a door that could open a portal back to Celum, they’d take it, Erin. I’m sorry, but we’re not going to be able to use it tonight. It’s too risky.”

“I almost want to give it to them.”

“That would be an unforgivable waste.”

Pisces glared at Erin, outraged at the very idea. She sighed, but nodded in agreement.

“Too bad. I guess I’ll stay with you. Maybe we can help fix stuff? I can clean—I’ve got a Skill. Or maybe I can cook? I guess we can’t go sightseeing. Everything’s in ruins!”

“It wasn’t once. There used to be quite a lot of buildings here.”

Ceria looked around at the ruined facades, wondering if she could see where the Adventurer's Guild had stood. Yvlon was silent too. The last time they'd been here was an age ago, when they had all met to debate going into Liscor's dungeon. Back then Calruz and Gerial had been alive and...

In the end, the Horns of Hammerad found themselves staying in a former inn now housing citizens alongside visitors. They had to sleep three to a room and Pisces found himself sharing a space with Termin and Ksmvr, much to his distaste. Termin opted to sleep in the stables, though, and Ksmvr agreed to go with him.

For the rest of the night Erin helped the innkeeper—an overworked, balding man who had a big scar on his right shoulder that was still healing—manage the inn. He nearly cried when he realized she could cook better than he could and happily surrendered his kitchen to her.

There wasn't much Erin could make with what few supplies were available to the city, but she made some potatoes and deer meat into a filling stew for everyone and found herself serving a vast number of people. When word got out she could cook, more food came in with requests that she make it for this group of people, or feed this family.

In the end, Erin only got to rest with the others when it was long since dark. She sat on a table, wishing there was a place to take a bath or shower in the city and knowing there was not.

"I can't thank you enough for your help. Your stew went down excellent and you fried that meat to perfection."

Umbral complimented Erin. She raised a thumb up and smiled weakly.

"Happy to help. How have you all managed to survive like this?"

He looked tired, but determined.

"It hasn't been easy. We had a lot of help, mainly from our city's savior. Ylawes Byres and his Silver Swords."

"Really?"

Erin saw Yvlon sit up a bit. The woman cleared her throat carefully.

"Will you tell us what happened?"

Umbral was only too happy to, and once the other citizens realized he was retelling the story they had to add their own accounts of what had happened, arguing with each other over the details.

The story was simple. After the Goblin attack, Esthelm had fallen into chaos. People had killed each other over scraps in the city and bands of thugs had fought with each other. The undead began rising since they hadn't

been buried and a second Goblin army had come to use them in some twisted scheme.

And then, Ylawes had come in, a literal knight in shining armor. He'd rallied the hearts of the people in the city and helped them fight back both undead and Goblins. With his help—and a timely rescue by a group of adventurers led by the other two members of his Gold-rank group, the Silver Swords, they'd fought the Goblin army off and begun rebuilding the city.

“Wow! Your brother is a hero!”

Erin whispered that to Yvlon as the citizens led them to a monument in the center of the city. It wasn't a statue—that was coming, according to Umbral, but there was a plaque celebrating Ylawes and his party.

Yvlon stared at the plaque silently. She seemed...distant, to Erin. Not unhappy, but not aglow over her brother's success either.

“He's always been a hero. I admire him greatly, Erin. Although I wish he'd not risk his life like this.”

“I guess I understand that. But he did save everyone. And—hey, what's that?”

There was a second monument next to the one for Ylawes. This one was a grave of all things. Erin didn't know how she felt about someone being buried right in the center of the city, but she was struck as she stared at the plain tombstone.

“Flowers?”

The grave was blooming with flowers despite the hard soil. Erin stared at it, wondering who it was for. There was no inscription.

“Yes. It's the strangest thing.”

Umbral explained when Erin and the others returned to the inn and asked about it.

“It marks, well, a young woman. A...hero, I suppose. She fought and died fighting the Goblins. And she was...Human. I think. That's what Ylawes said, and so we buried her as such. Her and the Goblins who fought for her.”

“Goblins?”

“They fought against their kind. And the undead. Don't ask me why. But if it hadn't been for them killing that damned skeleton with the purple eyes, I don't know what would have happened.”

Umbral didn't notice the way all the adventurers and Erin went quiet at this. He shook his head after Yvlon asked him whether Ylawes was still in the city.

"He went north, after leaving a group of those adventurers to help guard the city. Lazy pigs they are, too, not helping at all unless there's a monster about. Not like Sir Ylawes."

"Did he say why he went?"

"He was looking for his sister. Some adventurer—Yvlon Byres. Apparently he heard she was wounded and came south looking for her."

Erin bit her lip, but Yvlon just thanked Umbral and changed the topic.

"Do you think we'll get to Liscor tomorrow?"

Erin asked Termin before they all went to sleep. The wagon driver nodded, yawning and grinning at her.

"We'll get there before nightfall, don't you worry. I plan on having myself a good rest before heading back north. Maybe I can supply these folks with food and supplies? I reckon I could make a good profit. I don't suppose you have room for me and my horses in your inn, do you?"

Erin smiled widely at Termin. She gave him a quick hug, making the old man blush.

"Of course I've got room! You're welcome to stay as long as you want! I can't wait to get back."

As everyone retired to their rooms, Erin wondered if she should ask Yvlon about her brother. But Yvlon wasn't in the mood for talk, and so Erin eyed the bed, trying to figure out if she and Ceria and Yvlon could all squeeze in or if someone was getting the floor.

As they all squeezed in together, Erin whispered to Ceria.

"Ceria?"

"What is it, Erin?"

"Are the people here going to be okay?"

"What do you mean?"

"Well, Ylawes is gone. What if the Goblins come back?"

"They'll fight."

That came from Yvlon. Her voice was calm, distant, bordering on the verge of sleep.

"They survived two battles with Goblins. Every citizen in the city will have levelled from that. People will have gained classes, levelled up, learned to fight...if a city doesn't fall, it gets stronger from each disaster."

“Oh. That’s good.”

After a while Ceria spoke to Erin.

“Do you think Lyonette survived without you?”

Erin shifted uncomfortably—sleeping with someone else in the bed was not normal for her, but the other two women were used to company when necessary. She started to shrug and stopped before she shouldered Ceria in the face.

“She might. I just hope all the walls are standing when I get there. Oh well. Once I’m back, everything’s going to be a-okay!”

With that in mind, Erin went to sleep. The next day, the Horns of Hammerad set out for Liscor. They arrived just before evening as the sun was beginning to set.

When Lyonette woke up, she knew today was going to be a busy day. That was because all of her days were busy now. But she didn’t groan or stay asleep. She just got up, smiled as she pulled the blanket over Mrsha and the Gnoll curled up into a ball, and got to work.

Now that the Wandering Inn was busy, Lyonette found that being an innkeeper, or standing in for one, was a ton of work. Rather, she’d realized how hard just keeping an inn afloat was before now, but now she worked from dawn to dusk without pause just to keep everything running.

The first thing Lyonette did was haul water from the stream. She did it before the sun had risen in the sky, swearing as she hauled the heavy buckets up the slippery, snowy hill into the inn. And then she went down and did it again.

Her new guests drank a *lot* of water. And while Lyonette could melt snow, it was faster to haul buckets up to get a good supply going. Then she had to rekindle the fire before she could start cooking and that took time too.

And then of course there was actual cooking. Lyonette sweated over food for the morning, but eventually made a big pot of pasta and sausage to go along with the assorted eggs, ham, and fried potatoes and boiled greens for breakfast.

It was a lot of food, but she now had many guests. And as Mrsha thumped down the stairs Lyonette saw the first of her guests come down

now.

“Good morning, Mister Shivertail!”

“I told you to call me Zel. Mister and Shivertail aren’t my name at all.”

Zel Shivertail smiled at Lyonette. He sniffed the air and his tail twitched appreciatively. Mrsha’s was thumping the floorboards.

“Is breakfast ready? Don’t hurry on my account.”

“No, it’s ready! We’ve got pasta, fried potatoes, ham, eggs—Mrsha! Stay out of the kitchen!”

The Drake laughed.

“I’ll have some pasta for breakfast, why not? But first I need to use the restroom. Excuse me.”

“Oh—sure!”

Lyonette half-turned as she grabbed Mrsha to stop the Gnoll from running into the kitchen. Mrsha looked disappointed as Lyonette sat her at a table and got plates, utensils, and cups for both her and Zel.

“You sit, understand? You can eat with Zel—after you wash your paws!”

The young woman put no plate out for herself. She knew her other guests would be coming down the stairs soon, now that the smell of food was in the air. She just hoped she’d made enough!

Zel walked back into the inn with a gust of fresh air. Lyonette realized she’d forgotten to refill a bucket with water to wash with, and hurried to do that. She no longer questioned Erin anymore—

Lyonette corrected herself. She no longer questioned Erin just for being someone not born of royalty, but she had to wonder if the other girl had ever anticipated actually having guests in her inn.

Erin had a wonderfully large inn, magnificently crafted with glass windows no less, but it was missing some essential parts.

For instance, more than one outhouse. If there were more than four people living in the inn, having at least two seemed essential to Lyon, but Erin had never mentioned it. Plus, the outhouses were hardly big enough for some of her guests!

Poor Moore the half-Giant had had to find his own place to do his business for the first day, until Lyonette had talked to Pawn. The second outhouse was no bigger, but the third, temporary one was and Moore was quite happy with it.

There were nine private rooms in the inn, a very large number, but just enough for all the adventurers plus Zel, Lyon and Mrsha to sleep in if Mrsha and Lyon shared the same bed. Now that Lyon's inn was full of guests, she found that once one person woke up, they'd all be up within the hour.

"Good morning!"

Lyonette called out as the first sleepy person tromped downstairs, lured by the food Zel and Mrsha were happily devouring together. Jelaqua Ivirith smiled slowly at Lyonette, and the girl smiled back, despite the slight chill she got when she saw that the Selphid's host body had a bloodless open gash on her cheek.

"Good morning, Lyonette. Please don't mind the injury. I know it's distracting, but I didn't have time to fix it last night."

"Oh—it's no problem! Would you like to have something to eat? We've got pasta, eggs, bacon, bread, potatoes, ham—"

"All that? I'll have a portion of ham, then. With potatoes on the side. And can I get some of that honeyed milk? And some more honey on the side?"

"Right away!"

Lyonette bustled into the kitchen, calling out greetings as more adventurers descended. Some, like Seborn and Ulrien greeted her quietly, but others were grumpier in the morning. Revi and Typhenous looked upset to be awake; Halrac just looked grumpy.

"Good morning, Miss Lyon."

Moore was always polite. Lyon smiled up at him and told him what was on the menu.

"Anything you can have the most of, Miss Lyon. I try not to be picky."

That was one of the reasons why she needed so much food. Moore being half-Giant meant he ate three times as much as any of her other diners, hence her extensive preparations. But he never complained no matter what he ate; indeed, he was always polite, always seemingly grateful for the care Lyonette took to make sure he was fully fed.

Another thing Lyonette had noticed was each one of her guest's personalities, their likes and dislikes, but also how they functioned as a group.

Griffon Hunt reminded her of the groups of elite soldiers she'd seen relaxing off duty in the palace or on the streets. Halrac and Ulrien were

professionals, Halrac grumpy, Ulrien quiet and serious. Revi and Typhenous were typical mages in a sense, somewhat arrogant and condescending, not to mention picky when it came to relaxing, but equally competent at their job.

They argued a lot. Revi usually had a different opinion than Halrac, and the other two members had their own opinions. But Griffon Hunt settled their arguments by collective vote and for all their dysfunction, they were one solid team when it came to fighting.

The Halfseekers on the other hand were more like friends, and far more accepting of each other's opinions. They had to be, Lyonette supposed. They were all outcasts in some way.

"Thank you for the food, Miss Lyon."

Seborn nodded to her as she brought over his plate of eggs and bacon, and two pitchers of water. He drank as much as Moore ate, to keep his aquatic parts hydrated.

"No problem. Would you like more honey?"

"Please!"

Revi and Jelaqua raised their hands and then stared at each other. Jelaqua smiled and Revi looked away.

Honey was a very popular treat among all of Lyon's guests. With Lyon too as well; sweet things were a luxury and she loved a bit of honey with bread, or in her milk, or with almost anything, really. But Jelaqua liked honey more than anyone but Mrsha and Revi. She claimed Selphids loved the stuff on Baleros.

Revi just had a sweet tooth. Lyonette came over to their table with a small gravy boat full of honey and smiled at the four adventurers.

"Everyone doing okay?"

"We're quite happy, thank you."

Ulrien gave her a rare smile which made Lyonette beam. Halrac just grunted and Typhenous blinked and scowled at his plate. Lyonette hesitated, and then asked a question that had kept her up last night.

"I hate to ask, but...is it Griffin Hunt or Griffon Hunt?"

"Huh?"

They looked at her. Lyon blushed a bit.

"It's just—I've heard your name several times, but I kept wondering if it was spelled, uh Griffin or..."

It was Halrac who answered, with an even rarer smile. His was ironic.

“You have a good ear. We’re Griffon Hunt. Not Griffin as in the beast. We’re named after a breed of dog used for hunting, which is what we specialize in.”

“Really? *I* didn’t know that.”

Revi leaned over the table, staring at Halrac.

“But you and Ulrien used to hunt actual Griffins.”

“Yeah. But we’re named after the dog.”

“Why in the name of silk would you do that? No one I know thinks you’re named Griffon Hunt!”

“It’s a play on words. I didn’t come up with it.”

All eyes turned to Ulrien. He raised his hands.

“Not me. It was another member of our group.”

“Who?”

“She’s dead. It doesn’t matter.”

Halrac scowled, and that was it for the conversation for the day, Lyonette knew. She let the adventurers talk and troop out of the inn while she went over to the Halfseekers with a jug of milk.

“Anyone want more milk? Or honey with that? How about seconds?”

“I think we’re good, thank you Lyon.”

Jelaqua smiled again, and Lyon beamed. It made her happy that the adventurers actually smiled while staying here. She knew she had never smiled during breakfast when she was young, only complained about the food.

But both groups of adventurers were happy here. Halrac especially—he and the team of Griffon Hunt were pleased not to be spending so much coin—she’d heard him talking about how they were getting better service for a fraction of the cost ‘that damned Drake’ had charged. And the Halfseekers were happy to find an inn where they weren’t treated with suspicion or fear.

But a good inn was in the end just a place where they could be safe and sleep. Within twenty minutes of sitting down, all the adventurers were ready to go. They trooped out the doors, headed for the city or the dungeon and Lyonette cleaned up. Mrsha carried some plates too—mainly to lick them when she thought Lyon wasn’t looking—and Zel carried his dishes and Mrsha’s to the kitchen, despite Lyonette objecting.

“I’ll be heading into the city too. Would you like me to drop off a list of anything you need bought?”

“Thank you, but I think I’m good for today!”

He nodded and went out into the cold. Lyonette shivered a bit, and then got back to cleaning.

Washing dishes and getting the kitchen ready was another exhausting task. At least she only had to make food for Mrsha and herself for lunch. Sometimes she had to feed everyone then as well, which was very tiring.

Lyon had a moment to spare around midday, which made her pause and sigh in relief. Normally she'd be sorting the things she'd had bought from the city—the Gnoll Runner usually carried it up on a sled about now.

Since that fateful day when Mrsha had fallen into the dungeon—the day Lyonette thought of as a near disaster and the rest of the city thought of as a momentous occasion where a new route into the dungeon had been found—she'd been sort of unbanned from entering the city.

It was tricky. Lyonette was fairly certain that if she went through the gates, no one would stop her. The Drake [Guardsmen] certainly wouldn't, although she wasn't sure if the Gnolls would. Zel Shivertail's influence had granted her some kind of pardon, but Lyon didn't want to test it unless totally necessary, so she just sent shopping lists into the city with coin when she needed food or supplies.

Now she bought directly from Krshia, and the Gnoll came over sometimes to talk with and teach Mrsha. She rarely said much to Lyon, but she had taken a greater interest in the young Gnoll, although she'd said that she didn't have time to teach the young Gnoll much. And as Lyonette had learned, none of the other Gnolls were willing to get near Mrsha, much less teach her.

After a little while spent resting and then more time outside, playing catch with Mrsha and letting her run about after a small ball like a dog—although this one threw the ball back—Lyonette went back inside to fix a small problem she had.

It was that she had too much food. Ironical, that. Lyon bought in bulk now, in order to feed her guests. She had the funds for it—the adventurers and Zel paid a lot to stay here and none of them were tight with their coin. But there was a finite amount of room in the kitchen pantries to accommodate all the things Lyon bought, and she wondered if there was other space in the inn.

Zel found Lyon as she was opening a room she barely knew existed. He peeked over her shoulder as she stared into a supply closet.

“What's that?”

She whirled, jumping in surprise.

“You scared me!”

“Sorry.”

He smiled at her without exposing his teeth. Zel sat down tiredly as Lyonette peered inside the closet.

“I think this is some kind of...well, it’s too small to be a proper storage place. I wonder why it’s here. Oh, are you done with your tasks in the city?”

“For today. But there’s going to be a lot more, if all the [Message] spells I’ve been receiving are any clue. I’ve had to talk with Zevara, the local heads of all the Guilds...it’s a mess.”

Zel sighed. Lyonette wanted to go get him some tea or something stronger, but she’d spotted a small crack along the floorboards. She peered at it suspiciously.

“Is this...because of the Antinium? The new ones, I mean?”

Lyonette didn’t know much about the new Antinium that had sent Liscor into a frenzy, but she knew the one with the blue chitin had helped save Mrsha. That made Lyon trust her at least, but she had also heard the stories of the Antinium Wars and was uneasy about this sudden development. As was, it seemed, the continent.

“Yes. All the cities want to know what’s going on. They’re arguing, and it’s getting very political with Ilvriss around. But I’m also meeting to discuss the issue with the Goblin Lord and this dungeon.”

“Are you part of this city? I mean, do you live here or...?”

“No, but I feel responsible. And I try to help where I can, so I do. It’s a pain, though. Drakes can’t do anything without arguing over it endlessly, and like I said, when it gets political...”

“A lot of Human kingdoms are like that too. Or so I’ve heard.”

“Hah! At least there they don’t declare war on each other when a council member insults the Captain of the Watch’s tail. Or do they?”

“It can get pretty bad.”

Lyonette grinned ruefully as she shifted things aside. Yes, the hairline crack *was* there, and on purpose. She had a feeling she knew what it was and tried to pull things out of the way.

There was a sack of flour and other miscellaneous objects piled up on top of it. Zel came over and helped Lyonette shift everything out of the small space. She smiled at him.

“Thank you. Now, what’s this...?”

There was a trapdoor in the small closet. No, not a closet, but an entrance. Lyonette pulled at the ring and after a moment the trapdoor came up.

“What’s this? A basement?”

Zel and Lyon stared down the dark steps leading down into, yes, a basement of all things! Lyon was amazed—she took a few hesitant steps down and then had to cast the [Light] spell. It was one of the few she’d been taught as a child and it illuminated the very big, very empty basement.

“I had no idea this was here!”

“You didn’t?”

The Drake general walked down the steps, staring at the empty stone room. He pointed.

“Look, there’s places to store grain, shelves...this place is huge! Why hasn’t it been used?”

“I didn’t know about it! And Erin—I don’t know if she did either.”

“Erin? That’s the innkeeper who owns this place, isn’t it? Why didn’t she know about the basement?”

“I don’t think she knew. Or if she did, she might have forgot.”

“I can’t say I’m too impressed with this innkeeper of yours.”

Zel frowned as he stared around the basement. He looked sideways at Lyonette.

“She seems not to care about leaving you—and Mrsha—alone for so long, and with no coin or help, no less!”

“She does care! She’s just—distracted. And she gets into trouble, sometimes. I think she just found something—or got into a problem—and couldn’t come back. I mean, she cares a lot even if she does weird things...”

Lyonette tried to defend Erin, although she realized her arguments were less than compelling. Zel frowned, unhappy.

“I’d like to have a word with her when she gets back. She *is* coming back, isn’t she?”

“That’s what Selys said. Um, would you mind if I asked you to help carry some stuff down here?”

“I would be happy to help. And you can tell me more about this strange Human.”

In the end, Lyonette told Zel about Erin while they carried a good amount of foodstuffs and supplies down into the basement. He snorted

when he heard about her antics with the sleigh, Toren, and all of the other incredible and insane things Erin had done.

“I’ve fought alongside people like that. Distracted geniuses, prodigies without common sense...they tend to win some battles spectacularly and get torn apart in skirmishes they should easily win. I try not to have them in positions of command if I can. They’re not reliable in a pinch.”

“Well...she did save me. And though I was horrible to her, she never gave up on me.”

“That’s a redeeming trait, not an excuse.”

Lyon didn’t have an answer to that. In the end, they closed the basement trap door and only opened it when they realized Mrsha was trapped down in there.

“I told you not to play around!”

Lyon scolded Mrsha as the Gnoll raced back upstairs. Mrsha flattened her ears, but then glanced towards the door and sniffed at the air. Lyon put her hands on her hips.

“Hungry? I guess I should start making dinner, then! Everyone’s going to be coming back and probably starving after fighting monsters in the dungeon for so long.”

“Stressed out, too. It’s a hard job they have. This dungeon is filled with traps and rooms that keep changing. Even if they can bypass some of that and get into a new area, the way down is treacherous and there’s no easy escape. They need to take things carefully and meanwhile a bunch of inexperienced adventurers are going in and getting themselves killed or finding trouble.”

Zel explained the issue to Mrsha and Lyonette as she brought him a mug of ale. He drank it as Mrsha kept sniffing the air. Lyon was about to ask what was wrong when Mrsha suddenly sat up on her chair and *howled*.

It was sudden and made Lyon spin around in a panic. Zel was on his feet in a second. He stared out the window carefully, back against the wall.

“Mrsha, what is it, what’s wrong?”

Lyonette bent to Mrsha, but the Gnoll was suddenly filled with excitement. She hopped on the table and howled again, louder.

“It’s no monster. She’s not afraid.”

Zel relaxed as he observed Mrsha. Lyonette covered her ears—indoors the howling was insanely loud! Then he heard a distant howl from the city.

“Is that...Krshia?”

The other Gnoll had taught Mrsha how to howl, in some sort of Gnoll method of communicating. Lyonette didn't know if it was the other Gnoll's voice, but the instant Mrsha heard it she stopped howling.

"What was all that about?"

Lyon had no idea. She bent over the shards of the mug, picking them up gingerly, when she heard voices from outside.

"Oh? Are they back already?"

She started towards the door. But it was flung open before she could reach it. Mrsha leapt off the table and barrelled through it. Lyon heard a shout, a female voice, and then—laughter.

Her heart stopped and then began to beat faster in her chest. Lyon heard a female voice, a young woman's voice, laughing, and Mrsha's excited noises.

"Mrsha! Calm down. It's good to see you! Please get off. Please?"

Lyonette saw a shape in the door. She walked forwards slowly, and then saw a young woman standing in the light. Erin Solstice beamed as she walked into her inn, holding Mrsha in her arms. She blinked when she saw Lyonette, and blinked twice at Zel, but then smiled at Lyon.

"I'm back! Hey Lyon, did you miss me?"

The girl, the [Princess] and [Barmaid] and single living employee of the Wandering Inn, stared at Erin in silence for a moment. Then her eyes filled with tears and she flung herself at Erin and hugged her fiercely. And as Erin yelped in surprise and the adventurers and wagon driver accompanying her exclaimed, and the Drake general inside laid eyes on the owner of the inn for the first time, word began to spread.

At first it came with the howling outside the city. Few Drakes heard it, but the Gnolls raised their heads. And they heard the howl coming from Krshia, and knew.

One of the Gnolls on duty mentioned it to Relc, who flipped a table and upset the card game he was losing badly at.

"Erin's back! Hey! Call the game off! Erin's back! Where's Klb?"

It spread to the Watch Captain, who sighed, put her head in her claws, and groaned.

"This is all I need."

It was already in the marketplace. Selys jumped up and down excitedly as Krshia smiled.

“She’s back!”

Across the street, a young Drake nearly knocked over an entire display he was helping his uncle with.

“Erin’s back!? I have so much to show her!”

Lism grumbled as he watched his nephew sprint off.

“It’s just one more damn Human. Who cares?”

The Antinium cared. Pawn, Belgrade, Bird, Anand, and Garry all heard the news as one of the Workers delivered it. They unanimously elected Pawn, the only free member of their group, to go above and see her at once.

“And bring back food. Please?”

“I will. And I will be sure to petition Klbkch that we all might go visit her!”

Of course, Klbkch already knew Erin was back. He’d known the instant she passed into the floodplains around Liscor. He sighed as he stood in his small room and looked up towards the ceiling.

She was back.

“I take it this is good news?”

Xrn studied Klbkch as they sat across from one another. He nodded at her.

“Yes. Very good news. A Human girl—the innkeeper I had told you about—has returned to the city. I am afraid we must put off your discussion so that I might greet her.”

“You astonish me.”

The other Antinium’s voice was frankly shocked.

“You would put aside a conversation between us—the reason the Hives have sent their delegation here in the first place—for a single Human girl?”

“Oh yes. Because she is important.”

“Really?”

“Yes. And her presence here means...well, I believe things are going to become interesting once again.”

Xrn looked at him askance.

“You mean they aren’t already?”

“Not yet.”

“You have visitors from four Hives, a Drake [General]—Zel Shivertail no less—in the city, a Lord of the Wall and a new dungeon plus two Gold-

rank teams and Humans streaming into the city while a Goblin Lord roams the countryside. And this Human is what you think will make things *interesting?*”

“Yes.”

Klbcch smiled. He looked up towards the surface, and wondered, for the first time in a long while, what would happen next.

“She’s back. Erin Solstice is finally back.”

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Erin Solstice had returned. That phrase meant little to most people living in or around Liscor. The vast majority of Drakes, Gnolls, and newly arrived Humans did not know this young woman. They would not have cared about her returning if they did.

But it was curious that in a city that housed over a hundred thousand souls above ground and almost the same number underneath how many people *did* know of Erin Solstice. And yet, that knowledge wasn't consistent among species. Few Drakes knew. And of those that did, only a handful were friends with Erin.

More of the Gnolls knew of the girl, if only by name. But most had never met her. They simply understood of her existence in the larger framework of ambitions, triumphs, and failures that was part of their tribe's struggle to justify their place in the city. The Silverfang Gnolls heard the howl, but they let their leader decide what would happen next. She was still the one in charge, even if much of her authority had been lost.

And the Humans? It could be said that of all the adventurers, the ones that mattered knew Erin. Two Gold-rank teams heard the news. One group was merely interested and wondered if their place in the inn would be compromised. But the others were surprised to see one of their members, Halrac, smile.

Less than a hundred people above ground knew Erin's face. But below the earth, the Antinium knew her name. Even if they had never seen her before, every Worker, and now every Soldier knew her. Because she was significant. She had spoken to the Queen. She had made some Individual, and she was known to the Hive's Revalantor. She was special.

But Zel Shivertail knew none of that. All he had were his eyes, the few things he had heard about Erin, and the things he had seen. The things that she had left behind. His understanding of her was formed by absence, by seeing what she had not done and the people who knew her.

So he stopped in the center of the inn, the Wandering Inn, and saw Erin Solstice return. He heard her laughing, and then her exclamation as Lyon rushed at her.

“Whoa! Hey, Lyon! Lyonette? It’s good to see you but—are you crying?”

“You’re back!”

“I am, I am. But could you let me go? And Mrsha—”

The innkeeper was caught between the young Gnoll with white fur who was climbing all over her, and the young woman who was almost beside herself with emotion. Fear, relief, surprise—

More people crowded the doorway. A half-Elf helped pry the Gnoll off of Erin while Lyonette let go and sheepishly stepped back.

“I’m sorry. It’s just—you’re back!”

“Yeah, I am. Thanks, Ceria. And—wow, who’s this?”

The girl came further into the inn and saw Zel. She looked at Lyon and the girl hurriedly explained.

“That’s one of my—your guests! He’s staying here.”

“Guests? I have guests? You mean people are sleeping upstairs? Who?”

“Not right now—there’s actually two groups of adventurers sleeping upstairs at the moment. Every room is full—”

“What? You mean there’s no space for us?”

A male voice shouted from outside the inn, sounding outraged. The speaker stomped into the room, a Human young man in dirty robes.

“Calm down Pisces. There might be space—we could sleep in the common room. And even if there’s not, there’s plenty of room in the city. Probably.”

A female Human, a warrior by the looks of her, wearing light leather armor walked in after that. Zel noted her gear—worn material, but ill-fitting on her. Probably a new purchase. And the young man and half-Elf’s robes marked them as mages. Adventurers?

Then someone else followed the group into the inn. An ant-like creature with an armored blackish-brown carapace and three arms. Zel's claws clenched together before he made himself loosen his grip.

Antinium. The thing made Zel want to leave, or start a fight. But he held himself back. Why was one here?

"Pardon me Captain, Erin, but Termin is asking where his horses can be rested. Is there a stable nearby?"

"A stable? Why would I have that?"

"Most inns have a stable, Erin."

"Really? Oh yeah! Um. No, I don't have one Ksmvr. I guess Termin's going to have to put his horses in the city. Sorry!"

"I will convey that to him with tact."

The Antinium walked back out. Zel couldn't believe what he'd heard. That Antinium had a name? And it was—an adventurer?

Nothing made sense. But now the young woman was approaching him with a smile. Zel took a few steps and met her in the center of the room.

"Good evening, Miss. My apologies, I don't believe we've met. My name is Zel Shivertail."

Erin stared up at the tall Drake, blinking a few times at him.

"Whoa. You're tall. Um. Hi. I'm Erin Solstice. I sort of own this inn, but I've been gone...wait, did you say Shivertail? Are you related to Selys?"

Zel's nonexistent eyebrows rose.

"You know my niece?"

"Yeah, she's one of my friends! That's so weird!"

Erin stared round-eyed at Zel for a moment, and then came back to the topic at hand. She coughed a bit nervously. Zel realized he was looming a bit and tried not to. This young woman seemed, well, a lot like what he'd expected.

That was unfortunate.

“Well, I’ve been gone for a little bit. There was an uh, accident, but I’m back now! I hope Lyon—I mean, Lyonette’s been treating you well? Getting you food and cleaning the inn and stuff?”

It was a question, not a statement, and Zel noticed that too. He made himself smile at Lyon as the girl looked nervously at Erin.

“I couldn’t have asked for better hospitality while I’ve stayed here. Your employee has done an excellent job, Miss Solstice.”

“Call me Erin! And that’s great! Good job, Lyon. Let me just look around... um, make yourself at home, Zel! Ceria, Pisces, I guess put your stuff over there—I just want to check...”

She passed by Zel and he saw her enter the kitchen. Lyon followed after her, looking suddenly very anxious. Mrsha ran after both Human girls and Zel heard Erin exclaiming as he eyed the adventurers. They seemed to be discussing this new revelation near the doorway—the Human [Mage] was giving Zel the fisheye, although the Drake [General] doubted any Human would recognize him without an army at his back.

“Hey, nothing’s broken! And the inn isn’t burned down! Everything’s alright! Good job, Lyonette!”

Zel’s eyes narrowed fractionally. He glanced towards the kitchen and saw Erin come out of it. Lyon looked relieved. The girl was chattering to Erin as the young woman poked around the rest of her inn.

“I tried to keep everything like it was, but I had to put the blankets and... stuff on the ground somewhere else. I’ve been purchasing food, but I tried not to spend too much coin! Um, I kept it—”

“Yeah, cool. Did you make food? By yourself?”

“I did. It’s not very good...”

“See, I tried to teach you! Did anyone get sick? And wait—”

Erin stopped and stared at one part of the room. She hurried over and then exclaimed in horror.

“Hey! What happened to my *flowers*?”

She rushed over to the boxes of dirt standing at the windowsills. Zel saw Lyon grew pale. The girl hurried after Erin, wringing her hands as she tried to explain.

“I forgot. I’m so sorry. I just didn’t think of them until recently. But when I did I tried to water them, and some have started to sprout. But I found out something about the flowers. You see, when you were gone I was looking for food for the Antinium and—”

Erin interrupted the other girl brusquely. She fussed over the small yellow flowers, not looking directly at the girl. She was clearly upset, but she only bit her lip as she turned to face Lyonette.

“It’s okay, Lyon. I guess...you know what? It’s my fault. I shouldn’t have gone. I can save some of them, I think. And I mean, I shouldn’t have expected you to...well, it’s too bad. That’s all.”

There was a tone of condescension in Erin’s voice that irked Zel. She was treating Lyon as if the girl were completely incompetent. Zel remembered Lyon saying she had been a fool before, but that was not her now. And Erin didn’t see that.

“I’m really, *really* sorry. But I managed to use some of the dead flowers! I have more honey—I can show you!”

Lyon wanted to get Erin to follow her back into the kitchen, but the girl had turned back to the flowers.

“Honey? I’ll go see in a moment. Why don’t you uh, well, why don’t you help out, Lyon? You can get some water or something. I’ll make dinner in a bit, and then I’ll talk to all these guests...you’ve been feeding them and making beds and stuff, right?”

“But I—”

Erin turned back to face Lyon, frowning now. She took a deep breath as Lyon went still, looking uncertain.

“Look, Lyon, I’m really glad you’re not being a jerk anymore, but let me finish with this, okay? I can see...whatever it is you’ve done in a bit.”

With that, Erin went back to her flowers, checking each one for damage. Lyonette stepped back and Mrsha ran around her legs. She opened her mouth, and closed it before looking at her feet.

She looked hurt. And that was what made Zel act. He walked over, wondering if he'd regret this when he got kicked out. But he had to say it. Erin was too busy fussing over her flowers, so Zel tapped her politely on the shoulder with one claw.

"Excuse me, Miss."

Erin felt the tap on her shoulders and turned. Her heart jumped a bit in her chest as she saw the huge Drake, Zel Shivertail, Selys' uncle, staring down at her. It wasn't that he was a Drake, or really big that bothered her. It was more the expression of displeasure on his face.

"Excuse me, Miss."

"Um. Hi. Can I help you?"

He was slightly scary. Maybe it was the scars, the places where his scales didn't join together quite naturally, or Zel's huge, muscular body. He wasn't quite as...thick as Relc, but he was clearly a warrior as well. His green scales were tinted a bit grey, but what really distinguished him was his aura. In that, he had one.

He seemed like a rock. Or maybe it was a pillar? He projected something solid that made him hard to ignore, or forget. He wasn't the kind of person you'd want angry with you.

But he was angry or upset with Erin, for some reason. She tried to smile at him, but he wasn't smiling back.

"Is...something wrong?"

He was probably upset, even though he'd said those nice things about Lyon. Erin worried the girl had made a ton of mistakes while she'd been gone.

True, the inn was in one piece and everything looked good, except for the flowers, but Lyonette had to have screwed up something. Had she borrowed money to keep the inn supplied? And why wasn't Mrsha with Selys? Erin had countless questions she wanted to ask the girl in private. She had no idea why Lyonette had been silly enough to take in guests when she couldn't cook or...or Erin wasn't here.

"How should I put this?"

Zel stared down at her, frowning at Erin as she shifted uncomfortably. She saw Ceria looking up from her side of the room with a frown, but Erin waved a hand at her friend.

"What's the matter? If it's something Lyon did—I can fix it!"

"That is precisely my problem, Miss. I would ask you to please stop dismissing Miss Lyonette so casually. You do not understand what she has done, and you are acting quite rude to her."

Across the room, the Horns of Hammerad went silent. Erin froze.

"No I'm not."

"Yes, you are."

The Drake's eyes bored into Erin's.

"I realize it isn't my place to lecture you, but I cannot sit still and say nothing here. It is my understanding that you own this inn, isn't it?"

"Um, yes—"

"In that case, why did you leave this young woman alone, without any guidance? You have been absent from your inn for weeks. While you have been gone, this young lady has had to do everything without you, and with barely more than a handful of coins. If she had not been so resourceful, she might have starved or been hurt. I trust you know she was banned from the city?"

"I—I do, but—"

There was no getting a word in edgewise, Zel rolled on, staring hard at Erin as he continued speaking.

“Lyonette took matters into her own hands. Yes, she made mistakes, but you owe her respect, not condescension. She took care of your inn in your absence. She obtained food, even stole honey from Ashfire bees. She looked after this young Gnoll—and she even rescued her when Mrsha was in trouble. She offered me a place to stay and she has kept this inn in business. I don’t suggest she has taken your place, but she deserves your respect and acknowledgment.”

When he was done, no one could speak. Erin’s gaze had gone past Zel’s—she couldn’t meet his eyes. She looked over, and saw Lyonette standing to one side, and lower down, Mrsha staring reproachfully up at Erin.

Lyonette’s face was beet red and she was avoiding looking at Zel or Erin. For her part, Erin felt her cheeks igniting. Because, although it stung and she felt a bit angry at being lectured, she knew Zel was right.

He was like a grampa, although he wasn’t as old as one. But he was like a grampa in the sense that he was reassuring, oldish, and calm—until he got mad. Then it was like Erin was a kid again, being scolded by an adult. Because she’d made a mistake and she had to be told off.

But what did she say now? The uncomfortable moment dragged on, no one speaking. Zel had folded his arms, and Erin felt like she had to speak.

But what could she say? Now that she thought about it—now that the exhilaration and relief at returning had worn off and she was thinking, she could really see that the inn was fine. Great. Extraordinary, even.

The tables were clean. The floor was clean. There was a fire in the fireplace. The dishes in the kitchen had all been washed, and the pantry and larder were full. In fact, everything was more organized than Erin had left it. Lyon had no Skills in cleaning, but she’d kept the inn clean, and found guests. And one of them had just told Erin off because she was treating Lyon like a nuisance.

Erin’s face felt way too hot. She looked at Lyon, and saw the girl glancing away. Embarrassed. They were *both* embarrassed.

“You’re totally right.”

Erin said that at last. She looked at Zel, and then at Lyonette.

“I’m sorry, Lyonette. I guess I thought—”

“No, no. It’s my fault. I was horrible before you left. I didn’t—you have every right to think I’d have messed things up.”

The girl interrupted hastily. She seemed so different, almost like another person. Erin had a hard time believing it. She hadn’t believed it before, which is why she hadn’t noticed. But Lyon wasn’t haughty, she wasn’t rude. She was thinner, and she looked tired, but happier than Erin had ever seen her.

And Mrsha was sitting by Lyon, clearly attached to her. Erin took a deep breath.

“I’m still sorry. You did a great job. Mister Zel here is right. I shouldn’t judge. And I’m sorry for leaving. I didn’t want to, but...you did a great job, and I’m glad you kept the inn—and Mrsha safe. Thank you. Thank you so much.”

She trailed off. Lyon looked close to tears and Erin felt a bit emotional herself. She spread her arms.

“Hug?”

Lyonette hesitated, then hugged Erin. The two girls laughed a bit, and Zel turned his head, scratching at one scaled cheek. Across the inn, Erin thought she heard Pisces make a comment, but that was followed by a yelp as Ceria kicked him.

Mrsha ruined the moment by leaping from a table and onto the two girls. She made small sounds as Erin and Lyonette yelped and laughed. The Gnoll seemed wound up by Erin’s return, and she couldn’t stop sniffing at Erin, licking her, and running about.

“Okay Mrsha, I’m sorry. I’m sorry I left you too—how have you been?”

The young Gnoll stared up at Erin. She opened her mouth, paused, and then touched Erin’s leg with one paw. Erin bent down, and the Gnoll nuzzled her face. She was no dog, and there was something deep in her eyes that told Erin she understood.

“Sorry.”

Erin cuddled Mrsha, and then stood up. Zel was watching her.

“Thanks for saying that.”

He smiled, showing a few teeth.

“If you kicked me out for saying that, I wouldn’t be surprised. It wasn’t my place, but I had to say something.”

“No, it’s—”

Erin cleared her throat, embarrassed. She had to get the conversation away from this. She looked back and saw Ksmvr helping Yvlon carry the door in. Lyonette and Zel turned to stare as the door came through the doorway.

“Is that...a door?”

Erin laughed. She smiled at Lyonette and Zel.

“I’ve got some crazy stuff to show you all. Come on, Lyon. We can help everyone get the stuff off the wagon—there’s not much—and you can tell me all about what happened while you were away.”

“And the door?”

“It’s so cool!”

Lyonette caught Zel’s eye as Erin eagerly went over to the door and the adventurers. He was staring at the door and giving her a quizzical look. She shrugged, helplessly. That was Erin. But Lyonette had to smile too. She felt that same sense of strangeness around the other girl. Strangeness, yes, but also excitement, adventure, new thoughts and energy. If she had just one word for it, it would be—

Change.

It was by coincidence that the Halfseekers met Griffon Hunt on the way back towards the inn. It wasn’t dinner time yet, but the Halfseekers were

done with their efforts surrounding the dungeon today. Griffon Hunt on the other hand had returned early, due to Halrac hearing the news about Erin.

The two groups of adventurers nodded to each other when they met, but they were hardly inclined to strike up a conversation. They were allies for the purposes of taking the dungeon on and associates in the same line of work, but still strangers for the most part.

“I hear there’s a new innkeeper. Or rather, the old one’s come back.”

“So it seems.”

Revi nodded somewhat coldly to Jelaqua. The Selphid smiled and the Stitch-girl turned to Halrac.

“Is she really *that* important? Why are we returning now? Don’t tell me you like this Erin Solstice.”

Halrac looked irritable.

“No. I just want to see.”

“Fine, so long as we don’t have to pay more.”

Revi threw up her hands and walked back to talk with Typhenous and Ulrien. Jelaqua turned to the two members of her group.

“Hm. This Erin Solstice. Do we know her?”

“She’s the one who had that skeleton, remember? The one who punched that Gnoll warrior?”

Moore smiled a bit, and Jelaqua’s eyes widened in recollection.

“The one with the skeleton, right? Well, if she’ll tolerate us I’m fine with the undead wandering around. I really hope she doesn’t kick us out.”

“Hm. You did make her faint by opening your chest up, Jelaqua.”

“Damn. Was that her? Sorry, Moore, but you might not be able to get as comfy here as you hoped.”

“I’m sure she won’t be so prejudiced. Have faith.”

The adventurers reached the top of the hill, the Halfseekers arguing about what might change, Revi complaining and Ulrien and Typhenous listening. Halrac ignored the discussion and paused in front of the door. He pushed it open, and blinked.

“Hey there! *Halrac!*”

A young woman turned in the middle of the room, and a trio of struggling adventurers stopped wrestling with the thick wooden door to turn and look at the newcomers. Erin half-ran across the room and beamed at Halrac.

“*You’re* staying at my inn? Lyonette, you didn’t say Halrac was the one staying here!”

“You said you wanted it to be a surprise!”

Lyonette hurried over, smiling at Halrac and the other adventurers. They paused.

“Miss Solstice? We haven’t formally met. My name is Ulrien. I lead the team of Griffon Hunt.”

“Oh! Pleased to meet you!”

Erin started shaking hands. Revi came forwards, and Typhenous. Halrac grunted.

“My team. We’re staying at your inn.”

“I know, and that’s great. Come on in—sorry, I was in the doorway, wasn’t I? Come on in! There’s no food yet, but...oh! Are you the other Gold-rank team?”

Somewhat apprehensively, the Halfseekers stepped forwards. Erin was busy staring at Moore and Seborn, both of whom were used to the scrutiny, but the real test was Jelaqua. Erin smiled at the woman and then blinked and frowned as she saw the other woman’s deathly pale face.

“Hi, I’m Erin. Haven’t we met?”

“I believe so. My name is Jelaqua Ivirith. I lead the Halfseekers, who you see before you.”

Erin's eyes narrowed.

"Wait a second...you're that chest-bursting lady! The Selfad, right?"

Jelaqua nodded, not bothering to hold her breath because she didn't need to breathe that much unless she was talking. But she was nervous, until Erin stuck her hand out, beaming.

"Good to meet you!"

Bemusedly, Jelaqua blinked at Erin's proffered hand. She hesitated; touching a dead body's hand was not fun for any species. But there was no way to say that in a moment, so she gingerly shook Erin's hand. The girl shivered, but not in disgust.

"Whoa. That's cold. Oh wait, your body is dead, right? That's so...well, weird, but I guess Humans are weird too, right? Sorry, am I being rude? Wait, was what I said racist? Sorry!"

She smiled at Jelaqua, and then turned to Seborn and Moore.

"And you're a half-Giant? And a...Drowned Man? Are there Drowned Women, too? Come on in! Lyonette says she makes a ton of food for you, Mister Moore. I'll see if I can buy bigger plates. And bigger knives and forks, too! Oh, and do you need a bigger bed? I can probably get one made..."

The Halfseekers blinked as Erin talked them into the inn, showing not a hint of fear, suspicion, or even awkwardness around them. She just seemed curious and excited by the adventurers.

"Oh! And here's my friends. That's Ceria, Pisces, over there is Yvlon, and that's Ksmvr...they're the Horns of Hammerad, an adventuring team like the rest of you!"

Both Gold-rank teams turned to look at the others. The Horns of Hammerad froze, suddenly thrust into the spotlight as they fussed with the wooden door. Ceria turned red as she realized Erin was putting them on the same rank as Gold-rank adventurers, and Yvlon looked like she wanted to swallow her tongue. Only Pisces and Ksmvr seemed at ease—Pisces staring back at the other adventurers appraisingly, and Ksmvr nodding politely.

“You’re an adventuring team now? And you’ve reformed your old party, is that it?”

Jelaqua went over to Ceria, smiling as she greeted the half-Elf. Ceria nodded somewhat warily.

“That’s right. We’re a Silver-rank team. We uh, escorted Erin back to Liscor.”

“From where?”

Halrac frowned at Erin. It was Pisces who answered.

“Celum.”

“How’d you get all the way there?”

Erin debated telling Halrac, but decided to wait until she had more time.

“It’s a long story. But I’m back, and so...these are my friends. They’re going to be staying here.”

“Where? All the rooms are full.”

Revi pointed that out, glancing idly at the other adventurers. She didn’t say anything else, but the implication was clear. The rooms were full, and she wasn’t sharing with anyone. In terms of pecking order, she and the other Gold-rank adventurers far outranked a new team of Silver-rank adventurers.

Erin frowned, vexed. Already problems were popping up! She knew Lyonette had done well to get the other adventurers to stay here, but where were her friends supposed to sleep?

“I guess you guys can sleep in the common room, maybe. I mean, it’s not very private...”

Pisces looked very unhappy at the idea, and Ceria and Yvlon nodded slowly. Lyonette bit her tongue, then spoke up.

“What about the basement?”

“Basement?”

The young woman nodded, blushing as Erin stared blankly at her.

“You do have one.”

“I have a basement?”

Erin thought about this. She vaguely remembered...hadn't the Antinium built it? She followed Lyon over to the room and blinked as the girl pulled up the trap door. Erin walked down the steps and shouted in surprise.

“I have a basement!”

She came back upstairs, shaking her head in wonder.

“The things you learn...hey Ceria, do you think you guys could sleep in a basement?”

Ceria glanced at the others and nodded.

“Probably.”

“What? It will be cold down there! And what about privacy? I object!”

Pisces complained as he stomped over to stare at the basement in disgust.

“No problem. We can totally make this work. All I need are some blankets, a mattress, curtains—I bet we could even buy some bed stands in Liscor!”

“Or we could sleep in the Frenzied Hare. Isn't that a far simpler solution?”

Pisces sniffed as all eyes turned to him. He gestured at the door.

“The Frenzied Hare—or a more reputable inn, perhaps? It would be far more effective than sharing elbow room down there.”

“I'm afraid you won't find many rooms, even if you do know the owner of this inn.”

Typhenous called out to the others. He gestured towards the city through one of the windows.

“There's far too many people here. Every building, loft, and apartment in the city is getting more crowded by the minute.”

Erin laughed, making the old mage frown.

“The Frenzied Hare isn't here! It's in Celum!”

Everyone stared at her. Revi spoke slowly.

“Are you planning on heading north right away, then? Because if you’re going a hundred miles to sleep at a different inn...”

The other adventurers chuckled, but Erin’s eyes just sparkled. She turned to the Horns of Hammerad.

“We’ve gotta show them. Come on Pisces, is the door ready?”

He sniffed.

“The door hasn’t stopped being ready. It’s merely placement I was concerned with—”

Erin brushed past him and ran over to the door, which had been leaned against one wall. She beckoned Lyonette, Mrsha, and Zel over. The Drake stopped playing ‘catch the claw’ with Mrsha and walked over to stare at the door.

“What is it, Erin?”

The adventurers sitting or standing around the room stared in bemusement at the plain wooden door—all that is, except for Typhenous and Moore. Revi was openly yawning until Typhenous nudged her and pointed. Then she sat up straight in her chair.

The rest of the Gold-rank teams picked up on the cue, and stared harder at the door. Erin stood in front of it like a circus conductor about to unveil the biggest trick of the night.

“Alright, brace yourselves, everyone. A little bit ago, Ceria, Pisces, Yvlon, Ksmvr—they’re the Horns of Hammerad—they went into Albez with this map thing. And they found this. Well, they didn’t find this, but—”

Erin broke off as she realized she was losing her audience. She shook her head.

“Never mind. But they got this magical door. Look what it can do!”

She flung the door open, and spread her arms wide.

“It’s a portal door!”

There was no wall, behind the door. There should have been, but instead the amazed room of people stared straight into a second room, one filled with racks full of glowing potion bottles, workbenches with powdered ingredients and empty glass containers—

And sitting at one table, humming a song under her breath and putting a label on one bottle, a young woman with dark skin. She looked up, frowning at the sound of the door hitting the wall in Erin's inn.

Octavia froze, potion bottle in hand as she saw the room full of people all staring at her. She stared at the beaming Erin, at the open-mouthed Jelaqua, at Moore, blinking down at her, and then yelped as a white shape bounded towards her.

“Mrsha, no!”

Lyonette grabbed for the Gnoll. She caught Mrsha a second before the young Gnoll could cause havoc in Octavia's shop. The Stitch-girl slid off her seat.

“What in the name of exploding cauliflower is this, Erin?”

“Octavia! I'm back in my inn!”

The room—both rooms—erupted into sound as everyone began talking.

“Extraordinary! I can't believe it!”

“A magical door?”

“In *Celum*?”

Everyone started clustering around the door. Erin stepped through and beamed at the others as Pisces tried to explain.

“Isn't it so cool? I can go all the way to Celum just like that! And if I step back—”

She walked back through and spread her arms.

“I'm in Liscor!”

She hopped through again. Ceria frowned and opened her mouth.

“Hey Erin, that’s not the best—”

“In Celum! In Liscor!”

Erin jumped back and forth in rapid succession. Pisces turned and snapped.

“Don’t do that! You’ll exhaust the mana supply!”

“What? Oh—”

Erin half-turned to look back at Pisces as she jumped through the door again—

And the portal closed. One second the other room was there, full of noise, people—Erin could even smell them from Octavia’s shop—and then she was staring at a blank wall. Erin paused and then slowly poked the stone behind the door. Hopefully, she closed the door and opened it again.

Nothing happened. Sitting at her counter, Octavia smacked her forehead and groaned.

“You *idiot*.”

In the minutes after the door’s mana supply ran off, there was a lot of shouting. But adventurers being used to sudden changes, no one panicked too much. Except for Mrsha. Lyonette had to lift the howling Gnoll away from the door, and reassure her all was well.

Zel sat with her at a table as Lyonette coaxed Mrsha into sitting with her. The other adventurers were still standing around the door, although now an effort was going on to bring Erin back.

“Erin’s just gone for a little bit, okay Mrsha? It’s all okay. It was just an accident—no one’s hurt!”

“That was startling, though.”

Zel remarked as he stared back at the door. He eyed it, and the adventurers who were beginning to split off, leaving only the five mages to talk about what should be done. Lyonette thought his eyes lingered for a long time on Ksmvr.

“It’s a magical door. It must be incredibly powerful if it can teleport someone so far.”

“Yes. It’s an artifact worth—I can’t imagine. But it clearly has its limits, as your boss seems to have discovered.”

He did not look impressed. Zel turned to Lyonette.

“She has a very scattered personality.”

“It was an accident. She was—um.”

Lyonette stared at the door as the mages began to argue loudly. She saw Pisces standing protectively over the door as he and Typhenous began raising their voices.

“And what, pray tell, do you have to object to in the way I altered the enchantment? You will note I barely altered the matrix—”

“By creating a portal? That’s the element of the trap, don’t you see?”

Typhenous looked irritable as he poked the door with one finger, glaring at Pisces.

“It was clearly meant to open and reveal another room—thereby teleporting the incautious to another place entirely. But such a spell isn’t meant to safeguard the user! If it had closed on that young woman’s hand or leg she might have lost it entirely!”

Pisces turned red and Ceria interjected quickly.

“It was a mistake, but the key now is fixing it. If we work together we can probably—”

“We? Let Typhenous fix it. He’s the highest-level out of all of us.”

Revi interrupted, folding her arms. Lyonette winced as Mrsha turned to look. She knew conflict when she saw it, and this was the kind of battle she

was used to back home. Not physical, but social, a battle of willpower and hierarchy.

“Oh, is that so? And I take it you are an expert in enchanting magic?”

Pisces drew himself up as Ceria let out a hiss of exasperation. Typhenous stared back archly.

“Not a master, but I am well-versed in it from years of practice and time spent in dungeons. I was educated in the college of magic in the capital city of Pheron for twelve years. And you are...?”

“Pisces. I, and Ceria here, are graduates of Wistram.”

Revi and Typhenous blinked. Revi looked frankly incredulous—Typhenous muttered what looked like a spell under his breath.

“You two?”

“Correct.”

Pisces stared unflinchingly back while Ceria mumbled something in agreement. Typhenous nodded slightly to Revi, and her demeanor changed.

“Well...we might not be Wistram mages, but I was tutored by an expert. We’ve got the experience here—we’ll alter the enchantment on the door before we draw the girl back.”

Pisces’ eyes flashed.

“I am *fully* capable of doing any needed configuration myself. Your assistance would be useful—”

“It needn’t be a competition.”

The deep voice came from Moore, making all the other mages pause. He had been quiet, but now he looked disapprovingly around at the other four mages.

“We are all experts in some way, aren’t we? I have never been to Wistram, although I have dreamed about studying there. But since none of us specialize in enchantments, let us pool our knowledge.”

“It’s not a question of pooling, Moore.”

Typhenous looked unhappy as he glared at Pisces.

“As I was saying, the enchantments need reworking. If you look at how much magical energy this door drained from just a few moments of being active—”

“My spells did nothing to inhibit the costs! Ceria, back me up here.”

“Let’s all calm down and—”

Across the room, Ulrien and Halrac sat together with Jelaqua and Seborn. They were used to mages, and as such, gave them room. Jelaqua stared at Ceria and Pisces, looking thoughtful.

“Wistram mages?”

Seborn nodded.

“It seems as though they are. Typhenous was surprised. I wonder why?”

Ulrien spoke quietly.

“Probably because he didn’t believe it. I’ve heard Wistram mages are a cut above most other mages, even at lower levels.”

“Well, we knew Springwalker was good. Her team might be important to watch. More importantly, where the hells did they find that door? I heard them mention Albez, but I heard that ruin was tapped out decades ago!”

“Why not ask?”

Lyonette saw the Gold-rank adventurers get up and begin talking with Yvlon, who looked overwhelmed to be speaking with so many higher-ranking adventurers. She turned to Zel.

“It looks like there’s a lot of competition.”

The Drake nodded.

“Adventurers work together, but they also compete for the same things. These groups seem pretty mellow, actually. I’ve seen things get ugly fast,

although it might come to that if the mages don't cooperate."

"I'll do something about that."

Determinedly, Lyon stood up, letting Mrsha hop off her lap. Erin might be back, but Lyon could still be useful. The Gnoll followed her into the kitchen and in a few moments, came out chewing something in her mouth.

Lyon came out a few moments after that, holding a platter with cut cheese, some sliced bread, and sausage all sliced up. She approached the angry mages, holding the smorgasbord out in case someone cast a spell. They ignored her until she raised her voice tentatively.

"Excuse me. Would anyone like something to eat? Or drink?"

The bickering mages looked up. Like magic—a different kind of magic than was being argued over here—they stopped fighting as all five mages eagerly grabbed the snacks off of the plate. Moore, who hadn't really been that confrontational to begin with, smiled gratefully as Lyonette handed him a block of cheese she'd sliced into two parts and half a sausage on a plate of his own.

"Hm. Oh, thank you, my dear."

Typhenous smiled at Lyonette, and Ceria and Pisces remembered they hadn't eaten since breakfast as they shoved food into their mouths. Lyonette hurried back into the kitchen, and in a few minutes everyone was sipping from mugs and speaking far more calmly to each other.

"Yes, I see. I suppose we can simply concentrate our mana together to reactivate the doorway until a better solution can be found."

Typhenous brushed some crumbs off his beard and nodded at Pisces. The young man inclined his head as well.

"How would you like to focus it? Neither Ceria or I have a focusing agent ____"

"My staff would work well. Allow me."

Moore gently raised his staff and touched the door as he put his plate on one table. Typhenous nodded. He reached out and grasped Moore's other hand.

Revi stood by Typhenous' side; she linked hands with him.

"A good old fashioned link-up, is it? I haven't done one of these in ages. Do they do these in Wistram?"

"Not much. They have fancy crystals that let mages link up at a distance. I once saw a mage eating in the banquet hall while he helped power a spell two floors up."

Revi snorted as Pisces took her hand. Ceria offered her skeletal hand to Pisces, he took it, giving her a bemused look. She shrugged.

"Better conductivity."

"Just so long as you don't expect the rest of us to do a blood link."

"Hah!"

The other adventurers, Lyon, Zel, and Mrsha all watched as the mages grew silent. Lyonette had to pick up Mrsha to keep her from wandering over; she had a feeling serious magic was being done.

If it was though, it only took moments and, disappointingly, had no colorful effects or sounds to accompany it. The mages let go and Moore carefully pulled the door open.

"I'm telling you, you're not going to get it open even if you pour a thousand mana potions on it. Put that down!"

"How do you know? It *might* work. Let me try one!"

Octavia's shop appeared in the doorway again, as if nothing had happened. Erin and Octavia were caught in the center of the shop, fighting over a green bottle. They paused and turned to the door.

"Oh hey, the door works."

"You did it!"

Erin leapt through the door and beamed at the mages. They stepped back, looking slightly weary.

Revi flicked a bit of sweat off her forehead.

“That thing’s a mana sponge. No wonder it can’t run for more than a minute at best.”

“Thanks, guys!”

Erin beamed at the others, and then pointed at the door.

“Will this thing last for a while?”

“Longer than last time, if you don’t exhaust it by moving back and forth again.”

Pisces sat back into a chair and reached for another piece of cheese. Typhenous nodded.

“You have a wonderfully powerful artifact here, Miss Solstice. I would love to talk to you about it—and with you adventurers, if you have the chance. Perhaps over dinner?”

“Dinner! That’s right!”

Erin turned to the window in horror as she realized how late it was getting. She called out to Lyonette as the girl hurried over.

“Lyon, we’ve got to start making food! Tons of it!”

“I’ve got a bunch of it in the pantries, but there’s more in the basement. Should I...?”

“Great! Bring up whatever you need—I’ll start cooking! I’ve got [Advanced Cooking]!”

That made all the adventurers in the room, and Zel, sit up. Mrsha’s ears perked and the young Gnoll crept towards the kitchen to wait.

“Aw, you’re making food? Close the door before I smell it!”

Octavia groused to Erin as the girl began listing food for the appreciative crowd and accepting suggestions for what she should cook. Erin turned and smiled at Octavia.

“Why don’t you join us?”

“Join you?”

“Why not? Come on, lock up your shop and have a meal! You can talk to these guys while you wait—did you know everyone here’s an adventurer? Well, besides Zel and Mrsha and Lyonette—but these guys are Gold-rank adventurers?”

“Gold-rank adventurers?”

Octavia didn’t exactly teleport, but she was through the portal door in a flash. She offered a brown bottle filled with liquid that looked like it had tiny glowing fragments swirling around inside of it to Revi.

“Mana potion?”

“What? No, I don’t need—”

Revi tried to decline, but Octavia pushed the bottle into her hands.

“Free of charge. Complimentary. In fact, let me throw a stamina potion in as well. Have you tried my wares? Octavia’s the name. Please consider using my products if you’re ever in the area. I’d be happy to custom-brew anything you happen to need. In fact, I have a new line of defensive potions and items you might be interested in. Are any of you [Rogues]? I have this wonderful Smoke Sack—that’s what I’m calling it—that has incredible potency for the price. Let me just find you a sample...”

She began her sales pitch and Erin laughed as she walked into the kitchen. The night had gotten off to a bumpy start, but now? Now she felt like everything was beginning to be right.

More than right, in fact. Perfect. Lyonette was in the kitchen, already spreading out food on the countertops. She turned to Erin, looking pleading.

“Can I help? Or at least watch? I’ve got the [Basic Cooking] skill now, actually. I’m still no good, but—”

Erin smiled at the other girl and put a hand on her arm. She grinned, and after a moment Lyonette smiled back. In her corner, Mrsha smiled too, and stared at the food as she waited for the right moment to pounce.

Erin grabbed a knife. She had a feeling she’d need to make a ton of food tonight.

“Let’s get cooking.”

Klbgch walked up towards the inn on the hill outside Liscor, ignoring the cold snow that crunched around his uncovered feet. The Antinium didn’t have much use for clothes, but they were aware of their bodies’ inability to regulate extreme temperatures. Thus, Klbgch kept moving and only stopped in front of the door.

He hesitated. It would be good to see Erin again. But there was so much to talk about! What should he say?

Greetings first. Klbgch knocked and then wondered if he should have brought a gift. Wasn’t that customary after a long time?

Too late now. The Antinium waited, heart pounding a bit faster. He had so much that needed to be said, but perhaps it was Ryoka he should talk to? And yet, Erin was vital in so many ways...

After a moment, Klbgch realized no one had come to answer the door. He listened, and realized there was noise coming from inside. A *lot* of it.

Cautiously, Klbgch opened the door. A wave of sound, heat, and movement nearly overwhelmed his senses.

The inn was *packed*! Or at least, it was fuller than he had ever seen it. Klbgch walked into the room and saw Lyonette going from table to table with plates, carrying mugs, and Mrsha skulking between table legs, searching for scraps and occasionally stealing some from plates.

The room was filled with people Klbgch knew, and many people he didn’t. Griffon Hunt, the Halfseekers, and the Horns of Hammerad were occupying one section of the room, talking, arguing, laughing loudly. Across from them, a group of Humans and one Drake were eating, laughing and occasionally getting up to make some kind of speech. Klbgch was sure he’d never seen them in Liscor. Why was there a child with them? He was sitting with the female Drake.

And then—there was Selys, Krshia, a dark-skinned young woman he didn't know and...*Pawn*? The Antinium looked up and paused when he saw Klbkch. He was sitting with the Gnoll and Drake—and Ksmvr, of all beings. Klbkch knew he shouldn't have been surprised to see Ksmvr, but he hadn't expected the two Antinium to be sitting together.

Ksmvr froze when he saw Klbkch, but Klbkch ignored him. He saw Zel Shivertail, making his way over to the table with the adventurers. The Drake froze when he saw Klbkch, and then kept walking, stiffly.

So many people. But where was Erin? Klbkch looked around and then saw her. She was coming out of the kitchen. He made towards her instantly.

“Erin.”

“Klbkch!”

She greeted him the instant she saw him. Erin beamed and hugged Klbkch—he hugged her back, gingerly.

“How have you been? No, wait—it's good to see you! Do you want something to eat? Let me find you a place to sit!”

“Actually, Erin. I was hoping to converse with you about—”

“Sure, sure! But later, okay? I've got to keep serving—”

“Hey Erin!”

Someone raised his voice. Klbkch saw a man get to his feet unsteadily. He waved in Erin's direction.

“You have to give—show us again how to do the chant! The one with the [Witches]! We can't decide how it should be performed.”

“Oh, that one? Just a second!”

Erin called out and smiled at Klbkch, looking distracted.

“That's from *Macbeth*. It's a play. Oh, wait, you don't know what a play is. I'll explain it in a bit—just wait and I'll get Lyonette to bring you some fried bee!”

She ran off before Klbkch could say another word. Forlornly, the Antinium stood in place, staring around the room.

“Hey, Klb. Over here.”

Someone addressed him by name. Klbkch turned, and saw Relc sitting by himself at a table. The Drake grunted as Klbkch sat down. He had a huge bowl of corned beef in front of him, and three tankards. He drank from the fourth as Klbkch stared at him.

“Noisy, isn’t it?”

“It is unusual. I did not expect to see you here.”

“Why? Because I’m a Goblin-hating jerk?”

“Yes. Did Erin react negatively towards your presence?”

“I think she was too busy to get mad.”

The Drake stared moodily at his food.

“She said hi. And she didn’t kick me out. I guess that’s good, right?”

Klbkch nodded. There was so much *sound* here! He was used to noisy taverns and inns—it was practically their only state of being. But not here. This was different. And he wasn’t sure he liked it.

“Bee? Someone wanted—oh, hello Klbkch!”

Lyonette bustled over, a bee on a plate. She handed it to Klbkch and turned back to the kitchen. The Antinium stared at the bee, and realized he was hungry. As he ate, he spoke to Relc.

“You seem morose. Why? You being allowed to stay here seems to be a positive thing.”

“Yeah, I guess.”

Relc picked at his food. Klbkch crunched one of the bee’s legs in his mandibles, savoring the honey and butter coated onto the insect.

“It’s just...I feel like we’re not her guests, anymore, y’know? I mean, we’re guests here and we pay and get fed—and this is good grub, but we’re not

her guests anymore. We're just guests."

"I see."

Klbgch looked around the room. He looked at countless faces, all of whom knew Erin by name, and felt a sense of isolation in his chest.

"I feel the same way."

"See? It's not just me!"

Relc drained his mug. He waved for Lyonette to bring him another—and had to keep on waving because Lyonette was busy.

"I guess we didn't know what we had. But remember when Erin was just by herself? We could come in at any time and she'd be sitting with us..."

"It was pleasant."

Klbgch nodded as he tore pieces off of his bee. Relc smiled.

"Hah. Remember the pasta?"

"I do."

"And now—well, now I can look over and see old man Zel sitting right there. Zel Shiverail. The Tidebreaker himself. Eating in this inn. It's crazy."

Klbgch nodded silently. He knew that Relc knew of his past history. Klbgch was as famous as Zel. More famous. At least among his own kind. But the extent of that fame was diluted among other races. Relc had only known him as Klbgch the Slayer at first. It was not the same.

"And over there—two teams of Gold-rank adventurers. Gold-rank. You barely see them in the best inns in big cities, and there are two staying here. I could take any one of them on by myself, of course—"

"Of course. Understand I merely say this to act as a friend, not because I believe your combat skills are that advanced."

"—Shut up, Klbg. But I mean, look at them."

Relc lapsed into silence. Then he dug into his bowl with a spoon and munched down some beef. He wiped at his mouth, looking dispirited.

“Reminds me of when I was back in the army. It reminds me...nah, never mind. I just sorta feel like I’m out of shape, y’know?”

Klbgch nodded.

“I understand your sentiments.”

“I don’t. But I feel out of place and very worthless.”

The two looked over as Olesm collapsed into a seat next to them. The smaller Drake looked despondent as his light blue tail curled up around his chair leg. He slumped forwards onto the table, holding a nearly-empty mug in one claw. Olesm stared at the two guardsmen.

“Mind if I sit here?”

“Go ahead.”

“You appear to be sitting already.”

“Thanks.”

The Drake sighed, long and loud. Relc poked him with a claw.

“What’s eating you?”

“I wanted to talk to Erin, but she’s busy. And there are so many people here—I feel like I’m not important anymore. I mean, to her. Not that I thought I was—I just want to talk to her, okay?”

“Join the club.”

“Indeed.”

The three sat in silence. The food was good, the company was acceptable, but Erin wasn’t here. Or rather, she was close, but too busy.

After a while, Klbgch spoke.

“It is unseemly to sit and be depressed because of Erin’s good fortune. I believe we should mingle and enjoy ourselves. We will be able to converse with her in time.”

“Mingle? And do what?”

Relc looked annoyed. Klbkch stood up.

“Let us find out.”

Relc exchanged glances with Olesm, but then they stood and entered the party. And it was a party.

“Look at this door! *Look at this door!*”

Five minutes later, Relc was drunk, laughing, and having the time of his life. He was throwing pieces of bread through the door—which had been laid flat on the ground—into Octavia’s shop, trying to land it in Wesle’s mouth. Thus, he was actually tossing the bits of bread *down* onto the door’s entrance, whereupon they flew out of the doors sideways, aiming for Wesle as he lay on the floor in front of the enchanted door.

The physics involved created a far trickier game than normal, and the others crowded around the door were laughing.

“Stop making a mess in my shop!”

Octavia was shouting at Relc, but he didn’t seem to notice.

“You play so well! Have you been practicing?”

Olesm was dueling Pawn in one corner, and Typhenous, Ulrien and several other people were busy learning the game or playing it as well. Klbkch, standing to one side and eating his sixth bee, saw Erin move over to the game as if attracted by a magnet.

“Hey, I didn’t know you wanted to learn how to play, Lyonette!”

The girl blushed as she carefully placed pieces on the board. Her opponent, Krshia, was thinking hard as she scratched Mrsha by the ears. The Gnoll sat next to her, nibbling on some cheese, her belly round and full.

“Why don’t I teach you all how to play Go sometime? It’d be great!”

Erin was talking to Olesm and Pawn as Klbkch came over. Olesm looked confused.

“Go?”

“It’s a board game! Even more complex than chess! And it’s simple to make—well, sort of simple! I bet we could get a [Carpenter] to fix up a board for us in less than an hour!”

Erin shouted as she tried to explain the game. Olesm and Pawn crowded around Erin, and Klbkch couldn’t help but draw closer to listen too. Erin tried to share the general details of the game, but it was impossible to share everything in the noisy room.

“Later! We can do it later! I know how to play Shogi too...but I can’t remember what all the kanji on the pieces looks like so it’d be weird. But right now—does anyone want to play a game?”

“Me! Oh, me!”

Olesm practically begged Erin for the first game, and Pawn the second. Klbkch found himself playing Erin—but at the same time as she took on Typhenous *and* Olesm again.

And then—the party kept going. Some people had to sleep earlier, like Mrsha who was carried upstairs by Krshia, and others, like Jasi, left with her younger brother Grev because it was late. But no matter how many people left, Klbkch found that Erin was always talking to someone.

It was true, what Relc had said. Erin was no longer just his friend. Klbkch found that knowledge slightly painful.

He ran into Zel just once. The Drake had avoided him and all the other Antinium, choosing to hang out with the Humans, or other drakes in the room. But they bumped into each other while going to the bar for another drink.

“Zel Shivertail. Please excuse me.”

The Drake [General] stared at Klbkch with open hostility.

“Why do you know a Human [Innkeeper], Slayer?”

“I could ask you the same question. Coincidence, perhaps?”

“She seems like a decent enough Human, as they go. Foolish, young...but we were all young once. At least, I was. What I don’t understand is why

she'd ever befriend the Antinium."

Klbkch shifted. He was armed with his swords of course, but he had no desire to fight here. Especially because he would die in an instant. Well, it wasn't the death that bothered him, but the time it would take to revive.

"I do not wish to engage in hostilities here."

"I won't break the truce. But I don't have to pretend to like you."

Zel turned and walked away. Klbkch let him go. After a while, the Revalantor walked out of the inn, leaving some coins behind on a table for Erin. He stood outside on the snowy hilltop and decided to wait.

Lyonette had never been busier, and in a way, never been happier than tonight. She was running about, serving tables, acting like a common peasant in short. But this peasant was leveling. And this peasant was liked.

By Drakes. By Gnolls. By the Antinium, even. Some part of Lyon still thought of Drakes as warmongering monsters, and Gnolls as overgrown dogs. But it was a part of her that Lyon knew was stupid. When she had been starving, a Drake, Olesm, had brought her food. And she loved Mrsha.

And she also loved this inn. There was electricity in the air that night, a charged room that kept everyone up long, long into the night. In fact, it was closer to morning when the last people staggered out and the adventurers went upstairs—or down into the basement—to sleep.

Lyonette found herself dozing at one of the tables, trying to pile dishes while her eyelids drooped. Erin yawned as she made her way over.

"You sleep. I sleep. Tomorrow we'll..."

The sentence never finished. Erin just sort of wandered off.

"Here."

Someone took the plates away. Lyonette looked up and saw Zel smiling at her.

“You’re awake?”

She said it stupidly. Zel grinned.

“What can I say? I like parties, and I’m used to staying up days without sleep.”

“Oh.”

Lyonette turned and looked upstairs. It seemed like a long way to go. Zel chuckled.

“Need a tail? Or—claw? What is it you Humans say, a hand?”

“Something like that.”

The girl grinned at Zel as she saw, out of the corner of her eye, Erin wandering into the kitchen. The Drake frowned as he looked in that direction.

“Is she going to sleep there?”

“She used to.”

Sure enough, the two heard a *thump* and then faint snoring as Erin immediately fell asleep. Zel shook his head and Lyon grinned.

“She’s a good...good...”

“So you say.”

He started helping Lyonette towards the stairs. But she paused as she put her foot on the first step.

“Something’s happening. Something is...weird...”

Zel paused. Then he frowned.

“Yes. I can feel it too.”

He turned. Lyonette shivered, and looked towards the fire. But it was still hot—and she realized she wasn’t shivering in cold, but rather trembling.

The room was shaking.

“What...?”

“Earthquake?”

Zel looked around, ushering Lyonette towards a table. She stumbled towards it, but then realized something was wrong.

“No—look!”

She cried out as she pointed towards the walls. Zel turned and swore. The walls were trembling as well, and—*glowing*.

“What in the name of the Ancestors is *happening*?”

Lyonette held onto a table as she heard voices from above. People were waking back up, and stumbling around. She turned, and tried to run for the stairs.

“*Mrsha!*”

The light grew stronger. Lyonette cried out in fear, and then, suddenly, everything *stopped*. It was as if the world had been pushing, shaking as it moved towards something. But now the world had reached its conclusion. The inn returned to normal. The walls grew dark and still.

But it was not the same inn of a moment ago. Lyonette’s legs shook as she steadied herself on the staircase railing for support. She stood up, and stared around the room. Zel stared back.

“What—what happened? I feel...”

Something was different. It was in the air, in the walls, even in the ground. The atmosphere in the inn suddenly felt *charged* to Lyonette. Zel just stared at her, uncomprehending.

“Why did the shaking stop?”

“I don’t know. But can’t you feel that?”

He shook his head.

“Feel what?”

Lyonette stared at him. He couldn't feel it, but she could. Untrained as she was, she could feel it in every particle she breathed, every step she took as she walked across the floor of the inn. She raised her hand and concentrated.

“[Light].”

An orb of light drifted upwards from her hand. It glowed deep blue, and then shifted to a murky green; the color of the ocean depths that she had seen only once before. It was just an orb of light—

But it was far larger than it should be. As the ball of light flew upwards, it expanded, turning into a sphere, a tiny green planet of its own. And more orbs of light rose upwards as well, from the ground, the tables, hovering in the air, a constellation of slowly shifting lights.

“What is it?”

Zel stared wide-eyed at the lights. He looked back at Lyonette, but she was pale-faced too. She had never cast a spell like this before. This—was closer to [Illumination], a spell far beyond her. But all she had cast was [Light].

“What is it? How is this happening?”

“I don't know. But I can feel it. It's...everywhere.”

“What is?”

Lyonette held one of the softly glowing orbs out. It turned pure white, and she breathed the words.

“*Magic.*”

And she woke up, in the moments before the sun rose. Erin sat up as Lyonette and Zel stood in the common room. She stared at the glowing lights floating in her inn, and heard the words, the words that thundered in her mind.

[Innkeeper Level 30!]

[Conditions Met: Innkeeper → Magical Innkeeper Class!]

[Skill – Inn: Magical Grounds obtained!]

[Skill – Inn: Field of Preservation obtained!]

“Wow.”

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It was still dark, still quiet, when the door of the inn opened. It was not night. But it was not day either. This was the brief moment before dawn, the quietest, most empty time. The sun had not risen, but the sky was no longer quite as black.

The door to the inn slowly opened, and someone came out. They moved very slowly; the rest of the inn was completely asleep at last, an hour after all the magic had occurred. As it turned out, even something as dramatic as an inn becoming a magical inn couldn't keep people awake that much longer.

But the lone figure was still up. It closed the door and then peered upwards at the side of the inn.

This is what someone would have witnessed if they were waiting outside. A slight scraping sound, the sound of indrawn breath, scuffling. The figure climbed up onto the roof of the inn, muttering as snow cascaded down around them. But in the end, they were on top, and then quiet crunching followed their slow movement across the top of the inn.

A small flurry of snow swirled downwards as a small patch on the rooftop was cleared. After a few more seconds, the figure sighed as she took a seat, letting her legs dangle over the edge of the roof. Only then did she speak.

"Oh, hey Klbkch. I didn't see you down there."

Klbkch stepped out of the darkness and away from the wall he'd been standing next to. He nodded up at Erin Solstice.

"Good morning, Erin. I hope I did not alarm you?"

"I was about to scream, or throw something. I nearly had a heart attack. But why are you out here?"

"As a matter of fact, I was hoping to speak with you. But I did not anticipate you coming out here so early in the day. Or rather, late at night."

The two spoke very quietly, their voices swallowed up almost immediately by the snow and night. But now Erin's voice was filled with quiet amusement and astonishment.

"What, you were going to wait outside all night? That's so weird. Why were you waiting? Come on up!"

It took Klbkch only a few moments to leap upwards and pull himself onto the rooftop. He was far more agile than Erin and stronger, too. She moved over and he sat next to her. Erin was still warm from the inside; Klbkch seemed like a cold block of ice.

“Was it something really important? You could have just woken me up.”

“No. That would be discourteous. And my issue was not so pressing...I simply found talking to you last night to be difficult, so I decided to wait outside while I determined what exactly I should say.”

“Oh.”

Erin fell silent. She turned her head and looked at Klbkch. He sat still, not shivering, more like a statue than a living thing.

“I’m sorry I didn’t get to talk. I really am glad to see you. It’s just I had so much to do...”

“I understand. And the fault is mine for expecting complete attention.”

“No it’s not. We’re friends.”

“...It is good that you are well, Erin. Your departure was alarming as it was mysterious.”

“Yeah. It was.”

Erin exhaled slowly, letting a small trail of vapor fly upwards. Klbkch watched it dissipate.

“I am told your skeleton was the cause.”

“Yeah. He was.”

“That is regrettable.”

“Yeah.”

Klbkch was used to maintaining both sides of a conversation. He had worked with Relc for years and was used to the Drake’s moodiness. But with Erin, he found it was easiest to wait. Or rather, he wanted to wait and hear what she had to say rather than talk.

“You know, I was surprised by Lyonette. She really changed while I was gone.”

“It was dramatic, certainly. I was not aware of her transformation until this point.”

“She really did do a whole lot. She helped save Mrsha, took care of the inn—she even learned how to steal honey from those evil bees. By herself! And she got me new guests to stay at my inn.”

“The Gold-rank adventurers are certainly a boon.”

“Yeah. I’m glad they’re my guests. But that Zel Shivertail guy? He’s important too, isn’t he?”

Erin’s face turned to Klbkch. He couldn’t see her exact features in the dim light, but he saw her eyes meet his. He knew what question was coming, or thought he did. If it were anyone else, Klbkch might have hesitated or considered an untruth or partial truth. But with Erin he just nodded.

“Yes. He is a Drake [General]. A famous one.”

She shrugged as if that made no difference. Erin stared out at the walls of Liscor to the west. They were gray, imposing, a darker blob of color amid all the snow.

“He doesn’t like me. He thinks I’m irresponsible, silly, and sort of a jerk. Which is fair. But he hates you, Klbkch. I mean, *really* hates you.”

Klbkch stirred, looked at Erin.

“You could tell?”

She just smiled a bit.

“It was obvious. I saw him look at you a lot while I was serving food and chatting. The innkeeper sees everything, after all. Just like the butler, the maid, and the kids. It was obvious he didn’t like you—or Ksmvr or Pawn. And you—were the two of you enemies? In the war, I mean?”

“Yes.”

“Okay.”

The two paused, and then the conversation moved on. Klbkch looked at Erin, but saw very little behind her calm, somewhat tired expression. He didn’t know how she felt and was...afraid...to ask.

“There were many guests in your inn. I take it these were all acquaintances?”

“From Celum, yeah. It was good to see them, although they did get a bit crazy and trash Octavia’s shop. I was happy to see they were all doing well.”

“Indeed?”

“Yes. Jasi’s doing well. So is Grev, which is great. I mean, he’s not stealing anymore and he looks halfway cute now that he’s cleaned up. Even if he has a big nose.”

“I see. Will you tell me who Jasi and Grev are?”

“Oh—right. You don’t know.”

Erin looked sideways at Klbkch. He stared back. She smiled, and the night lit up a bit.

“There’s so much that happened. I mean, I know there’s a lot that happened with you over here—adventurers and dungeons and new Antinium and stuff. But would you like to hear what I did?”

“I believe I would.”

The two sat on the roof and talked for a while. It was the first conversation they’d had that was really between the two of them just catching up. Talking. Briefly, Erin told Klbkch the story of how she’d started putting on plays in Celum. Klbkch listened, nodding a few times and trying to imagine this strange activity Erin was performing.

“Such performances sound quite extraordinary, not to mention profitable. I would like to witness one if the occasion permits. Indeed, the city of Liscor may be receptive to such activities as well.”

“Would your Queen like it, do you think? Would that be one of the things which helps your Hive—putting on a play for her?”

He paused. And then he shook his head.

“I do not believe she would care to view a play. And if she did, I do not think she would understand it.”

“Really?”

Klbkch nodded.

“There are many things my people do not understand.”

“Like what?”

“Friendship. Laughter. Happiness. Ambition. Joy. Tears.”

“Really? You don’t understand tears? I mean, I know the Antinium don’t cry, but you don’t understand them?”

“I understand it is an action meant to express sadness. I do not understand why those who weep feel better after having done so.”

“I guess it’s because being sad helps. And crying is very sad.”

“Intriguing.”

“Isn’t it? Us Humans are so intriguing. Except that I think Antinium are way more interesting.”

“That is a rare perspective.”

“I know. A lot of people don’t like the Antinium. Well, everyone, really. When I was in Celum I heard terrible things. And I’ve been told you guys are evil by all kinds of people. You know Lady Magnolia?”

“I know her, yes.”

“She doesn’t like you.”

“I am aware.”

Klbgkch felt Erin looking at him again.

“Klbgkch, will you promise me to tell the truth if I ask you an important question?”

“...Yes.”

The Antinium closed his mandibles slowly. He gripped the tiles on top of the roof, hard enough to crack one slightly as Erin stared at him. At last, she asked.

“What do the Antinium want? Really want, I mean?”

“To live. We want to live.”

“Oh.”

The two sat in silence as the sky grew a bit brighter. Just a bit. Erin shivered and mumbled about bringing a blanket. Klbgkch sat in the cold, feeling it chill his entire body.

“If you guys want to live so badly, do you think you could live in peace? Not go to war, I mean? Be...nice to other nations?”

“It is doubtful.”

“Why?”

Klbgkch shifted in his seat, dislodging more snow.

“Understand I speak of all the Hives, not just my own. I may be unfamiliar with recent events that have transpired, but I understand the way the Queens think. For them, peace is a strange concept. We do not think in terms of peace and war. We simply build up to wars, the next conflict. We have only known war, never peace.”

“So this isn’t peace. You’re really planning on going to war?”

“Some Queens are. Others think we should ally against our true enemy.”

“Who? Wait, what about your Queen? Would she be friends with the Drakes and Gnolls and Humans?”

“I do not believe she knows how.”

“Really?”

“Yes. She does not understand friendship any more than I do.”

“But you’re friends with Relc, aren’t you?”

“I am his partner. And I have been so for years. I have accompanied him on many occasions, and yes, I consider myself his friend. But I do not understand how I came to be one. And my Queen has no friends.”

He heard Erin take in a slow breath.

“Not even you?”

“Not even me. What we have is different.”

It was more than five minutes before anyone spoke next. Klbkch could see Erin’s eyes and head drooping. She was tired. So was he, but neither moved to get out of the cold. At last, as the sky grew brighter, foreshadowing the dawn, Erin stretched. Then she stood up. She stood on the roof of her inn and stared around the wide, open plains filled with snow. Everything was motionless, as if she was looking at a painting rather than reality.

“The world’s gotten a lot bigger, Klbkch. I know it’s usually the opposite way around, but I feel like every time I think I understand things, it turns out I don’t really get anything at all.”

Erin paused, and stared at the cold, pale snow stretching in every direction around her.

“...Or maybe it’s that I was looking at the wrong things to begin with. Does that make sense?”

Klbkch shook his head.

“Not at all. Your statement was quite incomprehensible to me.”

“Well, good. I don’t think I understand it well myself. What I’m trying to say is—did you know I leveled up last night?”

“I noticed an odd phenomenon around your inn and surmised this was the case, yes.”

“I got to Level 30. I’m a [Magical Innkeeper] now. My inn is also magical, or it has a lot of mana in it.”

“Congratulations. This is a great accomplishment.”

Klbkch inclined his head to her. Erin smiled a bit, and then grew serious.

“Yeah. It’s great. But—it’s strange.”

“How so?”

She spread her arms wide, turning to take in her inn and everything around it.

“Just look, Klbkch. I’ve got so much now. A new inn, a magical inn, a helper, friends, guests, a lot of money—even a magical portal door. And that’s great, it really is. But it’s not as important anymore as it used to be. Money’s just...money, now. What’s important is something else.”

“And will you tell me what that is?”

“People. We went past Esthelm on the way here, did you know? It was attacked by Goblins.”

“I am aware. But the city repelled them and retook the walls, did they not?”

“They did. But they’re hungry, Klbkch. Hungry. A lot of people died and they’re afraid the Goblins will come back. They’re going to fight to the death if they do, but this Goblin Lord is hurting everyone.”

“Yes. Over fourteen villages have been destroyed and a Drake city took heavy casualties fighting off a Goblin army to the south.”

“I didn’t know about that.”

“It is not a pressing concern. Such occurrences are common during calamitous events.”

Erin frowned at the sitting Antinium.

“No, you don’t get it. I didn’t know, but I wanted to know. I need to know.”

“Why? It does not impact your life here.”

“But people died. People are suffering. What happened to the survivors? Did anyone survive?”

Klbkch paused.

“I did not inquire. Such information would be obtainable I believe. Again though, I must ask why you wish to know.”

“Because I care.”

“You care about Goblins.”

“I care about a lot of people. I’d like to help them, if I can.”

“Why?”

Erin stared at the distant mountaintops, where something bright was rising.

“Before I went to Celum, I was really only concerned about surviving. But now—now I care about my friends. I care about people, Klbkch. I care about whether they live or die. I care that Jasi couldn’t find work and that Grev felt he had to steal to survive. I care about Rags and why people hate Goblins. And I care about the people in Esthelm, how they’ll do, and about Krshia and her shop, about Mrsha and Lyonette and you—”

“Why?”

“I guess because we’re friends? Or—no. Because they’re people. Because caring is important. Because I think I can help. Look at my inn. I’ve got money, friends...why shouldn’t I help?”

Klbgkch stared at the young woman standing on the roof of her inn. He stood up and tried to see from her perspective.

“I do not understand, but I find myself admiring your perspectives. And yet, I must point out that aiding strangers has no benefit.”

“That’s a very Antinium thing of you to say, Klbgkch.”

“Thank you?”

“Who cares if it doesn’t help me? If it helps them then I’m doing a good job. And then we might be friends.”

“Friends. How are friends created? How does friendship work? How do you make friends?”

Klbgkch stared at Erin, wishing there were an easy answer. Something he could tell his Queen, tell the others, so he could change them. He did not expect a reply. But to his astonishment, Erin Solstice smiled and laughed out loud in pure amusement.

“Friends? That’s easy!”

“Really?”

She reached out and tapped Klbgkch on the chest, right where his heart would be if he were Human. Erin smiled as dawn broke.

“All you have to do is give.”

“Give? Give what, precisely?”

“Something. Anything. Give your time to someone else to talk, give a bit of trust, or a helping hand. Give them a second, and maybe you’ll get something back.”

“But what if you do not?”

“Then you don’t. Maybe you’ll never get anything no matter how much you give. Maybe you’ll never be friends. That’s how it works. But to make a friend, you have to try. Just try.”

The Human and the Antinium stood on the rooftop for a while staring at each other. Klbgkch stared at Erin, and then nodded.

“I believe I understand. If that is the case, anyone may be your friend. So then you care about everyone.”

“Because it’s the right thing to do. Because they’re people too. Because I can.”

“I have not heard that perspective before.”

“Really?”

Erin turned and looked around. She walked towards the edge of the roof and stared back at Klbgkch, perplexed.

“Why wouldn’t you think like that? Where I come from—well, some people think like that. We’re all people, aren’t we? Shouldn’t we help each other?”

“I have heard it said Humans help only Humans. I have seen Drakes help only their relatives. Gnolls help their species, but seldom others. Each race has their enemies, their rivals. The Antinium see nations and politics as a competition for resources.”

“Well, I don’t.”

Erin stepped off the roof. She landed on the ground and looked up at Klbkch.

“Come on. I’ll make breakfast, and then you can help me.”

He leapt off the roof and landed next to her.

“Do what, exactly?”

Erin smiled. It was a big smile, open and without guile. It was her smile, and it lit up the world.

“Something awesome.”

Lyonette woke up as dawn broke. She got out of bed, feeling her muscles aching and exhaustion on every line of her body. Mrsha was sound asleep next to her, snoring gently. Lyonette would have liked nothing better than to go to sleep, but she *had* to get up now. She had to feed all her guests, get ready for the day.

She trudged downstairs, automatically reciting the list of chores for the day when she heard the *pop* and sizzle of meat frying. She poked her head into the kitchen and saw Erin, frying and cooking away a storm in her kitchen while Klbkch sat on a stool next to her and peeled potatoes.

“Morning, Lyonette! I’ve got breakfast started and Klbkch got us a lot of water already. Do you want to bring in the rest of the dishes and help me wash them before everyone gets up?”

Lyon blinked at Erin a few times. Then she nodded and got to work.

“I can’t believe it. Can you sense the ambient mana in the air, Pisces?”

“I can and do, Ceria. It is simply astounding—when I consider the ramifications of such a Skill—”

The next morning, the inn was in an uproar. Well, a quiet uproar. Mainly confined to all the mages, really. The other adventurers just stared at their magic-using comrades when they exclaimed over Erin’s new Skill. Ulrien blinked constantly as Typhenous raved about the mana in the air, Halrac ignored Revi, and Yvlon plugged her ears rather than listen to Ceria and Pisces discuss what had happened.

To show solidarity, Ksmvr put two of his hands over his earholes. Jelaqua and Seborn listened to Moore out of politeness, but the Selphid’s eyes kept wandering in different directions.

In the end, the mages congregated at one table where they could properly express their amazement and get back more satisfactory responses.

“So? What’s the verdict? Is my inn cool or is it *magical*?”

Erin smiled as she brought over a basket of rolls to dip in the honey. Typhenous levitated the soft butter up and sliced some off. He accepted a roll with a smile for Erin.

“My dear, your Skill is nothing short of extraordinary. Why, I consider it quite an achievement to have created for all intents and purposes a magical leyline in your own inn. When I think of the positive applications...”

“Yeah, it’s cool, but I can’t do magic. Does this mean all your spells are super-powerful now?”

Erin propped her hands on her hips as she regarded the mages with amusement. Ceria shrugged.

“It’s not as if they’ll become *that* much more powerful, but we could cast the same spell almost twice as many times here. And like Lyonette found out, if no one else is using the magic here, it can accumulate and boost a low-level spell to a great degree.”

“That’s super-powerful. Well, I’m glad it helps. I just hope it’ll recharge my door faster.”

“At the very least it will!”

Pisces seemed outraged by Erin’s lack of enthusiasm. He ripped one roll apart and dipped both ends in the honey, glaring at her.

“Do you understand—mph—what this—nmf—could mean? You could use the mana supply here to power any number of enchantments—”

“Ew. Don’t talk when you’re eating. You mean, like the [Field of Preservation] Skill?”

“It certainly seems that way.”

Moore smiled as Erin presented him with a roll that was more like a loaf. She thought about this as the mages’ conversation about what they might use the mana source for devolved into an argument over who would get how many rolls. But their conversation *had* given Erin an idea.

“Hey, Lyonette! Want to try an experiment?”

She called the young girl over and brought out an apple. It was a small one, and slightly wizened—not to mention expensive! Erin sliced it open and both she and Lyonette stared at the pale slice of apple.

After a while, Lyonette coughed.

“Um, shouldn’t we come back later?”

“Right...”

Erin slapped her head and left the apple. She bent down to catch Mrsha before the Gnoll could leap onto the table and grab the apple for herself.

“Hey there Mrsha, how are you doing on this fine day? Do you think my new Skills are cool?”

Mrsha licked at Erin’s face frantically, making the young woman laugh and let go.

“Hey! Stop that!”

“Mrsha, don’t bother Erin! You can play after breakfast.”

Lyonette pulled Mrsha back. As she put the reluctant Gnoll on the ground, she saw Erin giving her an appraising look, far different from yesterday.

“You’re pretty good at handling Mrsha, aren’t you?”

“Well...I suppose I have had practice.”

“Good! Actually, that’s great.”

Erin smiled at Lyonette, and the girl flushed with pride. Erin turned and frowned around her busy inn.

“Last night you told me you stole something else from those evil bees, right? Honey, dead bees, and...uh, what was it? A larva? Where is it?”

“Oh! I put it in my room so it wouldn’t bother anyone. I can go get it—”

“Why don’t you show me?”

The two Humans went up the stairs, Mrsha right on their heels. Erin peered at the fat, yellowish-white grub sitting in the bowl of slightly congealed liquid and shuddered.

“Aw. It’s so...gross.”

Lyonette giggled.

“Isn’t it? I was going to feed it to Klbkch, but then I got a [Beast Tamer] class! Um...”

“You want to keep it?”

Erin gave her the fish eye. Lyonette nodded.

“It grows on you. And it’s not hard to feed—I keep adding more royal jelly to the bowl. Actually, I’ll need a bigger bowl; it keeps getting bigger.”

Erin studied the slowly wriggling grub. She frowned at it pensively.

“Have you named it?”

“What?”

“You’ve gotta give it a name. How about Pudge?”

“Pudge?”

“Well, it sort of looks like Pudge, don’t you think? No? Okay, what about a bee name? It’s going to turn into a bee someday, so how about... Buzz?”

Lyonette frowned at Erin.

“I don’t know. Those names sound a bit...”

“Wait, I’ve got it! *Beeyonce*. That’s perfect! No—wait, that’s horrible. Let me try again...”

“It’s just a grub. You don’t *have* to name it yet.”

“Apis? That’s the word for bee in uh, Latin. I think. Buzzana? Buzzany? Is it a boy or a girl bee?”

Lyonette just stared. Erin tried out several more names, and then realized she was getting a funny look from Mrsha as well. She threw up her hands and walked away.

“Fine! You can name the bee whatever you want when it gets big. But for now I’m calling him Mr. Ugly Fat Worm. It is a him, right?”

Lyonette and Mrsha exchanged a glance. The Gnoll reached out to poke the big larva and Lyonette smacked her paw away.

“What *are* you planning on doing now that you’re a Level 30 [Innkeeper]?”

Jelaqua asked as Erin went around the room with a pitcher, refilling cups. Erin paused and then shrugged.

“I’ve got some ideas. I mean, I’m not going to expand or anything; this is plenty for me as it is. But I might do more with what I have.”

The Selphid raised her eyebrows.

“Oh? Such as?”

“You’ll see. In fact, you’ll see in five minutes if you wait. I might need your group’s help for something I have in mind.”

“Really now. In that case, I think I’ll have a refill.”

Jelaqua smiled and leaned back in her chair as Erin filled her cup and moved on. Seborn leaned over to her.

“What do you think she has in mind that involves us?”

“No idea, but I’m curious, aren’t you? I heard stories all over Liscor about the crazy innkeeper, but we missed all the action. I want to be up close and personal for this one.”

One table over, Zel turned his head to frown at Erin’s back. He wasn’t so positive as the Selphid, and his premonition only got worse when Erin marched back over to the table full of mages.

“Hey, can I ask you guys to do an estimate for me?”

“Of course. About what?”

Ceria frowned as Erin pointed to the door.

“Now that I’ve got mana coming out of the walls and stuff, how much do you think I’d be able to transport through the door? I mean, in pounds? Or is it kilograms?”

The mages glanced around the table and began to speak. Pisces was the first person to come up with a response that wasn’t immediately shot down.

“I would wager the door could transport, oh, sixteen to thirty bodies between Celum and Liscor on a daily basis. I say sixteen as a lower estimate given the increased costs based on weight and mass, you see. If you had a group of armed warriors, sixteen would indeed be...”

“Okay, that’s not bad. But what if you all added your mana to it? How many then?”

Pisces broke off, looking confused. Revi exchanged glances with Typhenous.

“Well, we could add a lot. If you mean like last night, to bring a lot of people through—”

“No, I mean as much as you can. What if you drank mana potions, and put in *everything* you had into the door? How many people could you transport then?”

Ceria frowned.

“At least a hundred. But why? Erin, you aren’t planning on actually turning your door into a big shortcut between the cities, are you? Because

mana potions aren't cheap, and neither are mages. We could do it once or twice, but adding our mana to the door isn't *that* easy."

"No problem. You'd only have to do it once. And I guess one hundred people is good, but not enough. What if you went and got more mages?"

"What?"

Erin leaned forwards and put her hands on the table as she stared at the astonished mages. The other Gold-rank teams had stopped eating and were listening closely. Klbkch, sitting alone at his table, raised his head and waited, uncertain of what was coming next, but certain that it would be 'awesome'.

"Mister Typhenous and Miss Revi—can I call you guys Typhenous and Revi? You're big shot adventurers, right? And so are you, right Moore?"

"I'd say so."

"By some standards, yes."

"Among local adventurers, we are somewhat well known."

Erin turned to look at Pisces and Ceria.

"And you two guys are Wistram mages, right? That's important too, isn't it?"

The two Silver-rank adventures fidgeted. Ceria coughed, blushing slightly.

"Not as important as Gold-rank, Erin—"

"That's fine. But if I asked you to, could you get all of the mages in Celum and Liscor to come here and charge the door?"

"Why?"

Everyone looked astounded, but Erin just grinned.

"I want to bring in supplies. And people! Adventurers, [Guardsmen], [Guardswomen] too—I know there are some in Celum, food, clothing, blankets, pillows...I want as much of it as this door can teleport, today."

"Why? What is this all for? And where would you put it?"

Revi looked exasperated as she asked. Pisces' mouth formed an 'o' of comprehension as Erin smiled at the Stitch-mage.

"Esthelm."

The room fell silent. Halrac blinked, and Ulrien sat up at the same time Jelaqua nudged Seborn with an elbow. The Selphid's whisper was quite audible.

"See? What did I tell you? Isn't she *great*?"

"You want to send aid to Esthelm?"

“That’s right.”

Erin turned and met Zel’s eyes confidently. Revi frowned.

“No offense Erin, but why would you want to do that? Esthelm isn’t your home, is it? Why would you waste your coin and energy helping them out? I heard they already had control of the city, anyways.”

“But they need food. I went through there the other day—they might be in control, but their walls aren’t great, and they need blankets, supplies—more people. If Celum and the other cities are too afraid to send help down the roads, why not come up from Liscor instead?”

“There’s still danger on the roads, though. The area around Liscor isn’t safe from Goblin attacks.”

“Yeah, but what if we sent a huge Antinium army and a bunch of Gold-rank adventurers with all the wagons to protect them?”

“What?”

Halrac and Jelaqua said it at the same time as Zel. At opposite ends of the room, Ksmvr and Klbkch sat up.

“My Queen would never allow—”

“Erin, I do not believe I could persuade my Queen to—”

Both Antinium broke off. Ksmvr shrank down in his seat while Klbkch stared, until the Antinium looked away. Erin stared around the room, frowning slightly.

“Well, why not?”

“Erin, you can’t just ask an *Antinium* army to go marching—and you want Celum to just hand over all the goods? Your idea is...I mean it’s crazy...”

Ceria shook her head, frowning. But to her surprise, Yvlon stood up.

“Why not?”

Everyone looked at her. Yvlon looked at Erin.

“I think it could work.”

Revi raised her eyebrows incredulously.

“You do? Because I think it’s crazy too, like Miss Half-Elf said.”

“I think it can be done. Celum has the supplies and manpower to send—it’s just a matter of convincing their leaders to act. And if Ksmvr and Klbkch talk to their Queen—”

“Um. I am technically banned from entering my Hive—”

“And I do not know if I can convince my Queen.”

Erin stared at Klbkch. He was giving her an odd look. She walked over to him.

“Are you sure?”

He stared into her eyes. Klbkch’s face was inexpressive, but Erin could tell by the way his mandibles opened and shut repeatedly that he was troubled.

“I...could try. But I do not have high hopes of convincing my Queen.”

“And are we just going to ignore the part where you get an army of wagon drivers to take everything to Esthelm? Where are you going to get that? And are you going to pay for all of this, or do you expect Celum to foot the bill? I don’t think Liscor would pay to help Humans.”

Revi kept talking, determined to point out the obvious. She indicated Typhenous, Ulrien, and Halrac with one hand.

“And what’s this about volunteering us to guard the wagons? We might be guests here, Erin, but we don’t work for free.”

“I’ll let you stay for free if you help. And I can pay.”

Erin turned back to Revi, putting her hands on her hips. She stared challengingly around the room.

“Why can’t this work? Okay, it’s sudden, and okay, it’s crazy, but so what? There’s a city that needs help, thousands of people that could starve if someone doesn’t do something. Why not us?”

“Why should we do it?”

That came from Ulrien. Jelaqua glared, but Ulrien’s face wasn’t hostile. He was impassive, questioning. Erin stared at the big man without flinching.

“Because it’s the right thing to do. And I’ll make you a huge lunch for the road. Plus, you’ll be famous if you help.”

Ulrien thought about that for a few seconds, and then glanced at Halrac. The [Scout] nodded. Ulrien looked back at Erin and gave her a slight smile.

“We’re in. We’ll help—free of charge.”

“What?”

Revi cried out in shock, but Typhenous smiled and stroked his beard.

“Don’t fuss, Revi. This is for a good cause. Besides, I think this might prove to be quite an entertaining diversion.”

“We’re in too!”

Jelaqua shot to her feet, visibly disappointed not to be the first to offer. Moore stood up as well.

“This is a big undertaking for one day. Are you sure we can do it in the time given?”

Erin smiled up at him. Moore’s lips curved upwards in reply.

“I think we can do it. And if we split up, why not? All we have to do is get someone to yell at the Mage’s Guild in Celum—why not Revi and Typhenous and you? I bet you could scare the socks off of them. And if Halrac, Jelaqua, Ulrien and Seborn all go to visit the Council—”

“Do you think they’d listen to a few Gold-rank adventurers?”

Jelaqua frowned, but Ulrien nodded confidently.

“We’ve talked with city leaders before. It can’t be worse than persuading them to evacuate a neighborhood or muster the local army.”

Halrac was decisive. He seemed to be the most passionate, if his scowl was any indication.

“We can do it. Gold-rank adventurers have the pull, and this is an issue that the city-states agree on. They support one another or they all fall.”

“Huh. Using our authority and good name to influence others. Well, it’s never worked for *our* team, but I’ll try and help.”

Jelaqua grinned as she pushed her plate back. Erin turned to Klbkch.

“Can you go and talk to your Queen? If she can send, I dunno, some Soldiers and a lot of Workers to help, that would be great. And if your Hive has supplies they can spare like wood and stuff...”

Klbkch seemed torn. At last, he nodded.

“I will speak with her. I cannot promise you she will agree, but I will try, Erin.”

Erin smiled at him.

“Thanks, Klbkch.”

He stopped, wavered. And then Klbkch nodded firmly.

“Forget my last statement. I will obtain what is needed.”

“Thanks. And uh, I hate to ask, but I guess we need to talk to someone in Liscor. Do you know if Watch Captain Zevara could...?”

“Leave the Watch Captain—and the city leaders—to me, Miss Solstice.”

Zel Shivertail walked forwards. He didn’t look at Klbkch as the Antinium stood aside, but he smiled a bit as he stared down at Erin. He seemed bemused, but he too was smiling.

“I think I can get them to pay for a few wagons, at the very least. I’ll head down and talk with them now.”

“Oh, would you really? Thanks so much!”

Erin was full of gratitude, but Zel just shook his head slowly.

“I—it would be my pleasure, Erin. This is a good idea, and a good cause.”

He headed towards the door, catching Lyonette’s eye on the way over. Zel shook his head as she beamed at him.

“What about us, then, Erin?”

Ceria stood with Yvlon, Pisces, and Ksmvr. Erin turned to them, full of excitement and energy as the adventurers began to argue about how best to approach things.

“I need you guys to coordinate Liscor’s Mage Guild. They do have one, right...? Okay, so you guys can charge the door up as much as you can here—Pisces and Ceria, you know how to do that, right? And Yvlon and Ksmvr can help me organize the wagons. There’ll be goods coming through that door fast, so we need a lot of people to haul stuff away—”

“What about us?”

Lyonette came over, excited, Mrsha leaping from table to table as she did. Erin laughed as Moore snagged Mrsha out of the air and put the Gnoll gently down on the ground.

“You can help me clean up and cook more food!”

“Cook? But what about helping...?”

Lyonette’s face fell. Erin shook her head.

“We’ve got to feed everyone, right? All the people hauling food through from Celum and the wagon drivers—not to mention the Antinium and adventurers—we need to make food for all of them!”

The [Barmaid] paled at the thought and Erin laughed again. She turned to the others.

“Okay, let’s get to work! Spread the word if you can—we need all the help we can get! I mean, these are a lot of wagons, right? Even with the Antinium Klbkch can get, we need protection in case of monsters or Goblins or...Rock Crabs.”

Jelaqua raised her hand.

“Why don’t we go to the Adventurer’s Guilds instead of the city leaders? We could probably talk a good number into some easy guard duty, especially if the cities will hire them for a day.”

“Good idea!”

Yvlon nodded towards the door.

“And I’ll go find Termin. He’s sure to know all the wagon-drivers in the city.”

“In that case, why don’t I go find Garia and Fals? A few dozen [Runners] could carry quite a bit, especially if they made several trips.”

Ceria nodded towards the already open door as Halrac, Ulrien, Revi, and Typhenous walked through. Erin spotted Octavia trying to intercept the Gold-rank adventurers and they nearly ran the [Alchemist] over. The Horns of Hammerad headed towards the doors, the Halfseekers split up and in moments, the inn was empty save for Lyonette and Mrsha.

The girl and Gnoll stood together, staring around the room. Lyonette stared at Mrsha; Mrsha stared at the open portal door, and then at Lyonette.

“I guess we’d better get to work, huh?”

Mrsha nodded, and stood up on two legs to help carry plates. Lyonette smiled, and stared towards the door Zel had walked out of.

“I *told* you she’s weird. In a good way.”

The city was in an uproar. Which city? Well, Celum was mainly full of chaos, as all the normal day-to-day foot traffic and vehicles found themselves blocked off by [Guardsmen] who escorted rumbling wagons down the street. There was a lot of shouting and confusion. What was happening?

Word spread throughout the city. Apparently, aid was being sent to Esthelm! That news amazed all those who heard it. So soon? Of course, Esthelm needed help, but the roads were not safe! Had something changed?

But the wagons weren’t going towards the gates. Rather, they were going to a small but well-known [Alchemist]’s shop that looked like it was under siege. Countless people were going in and out of the doors, [Laborers] bringing in bag after bag of grain and crates of goods and [Runners] going into the shop but never going out.

In fact, as the day wore on someone created a second door in the shop, and then just knocked the entire wall in, much to Octavia’s displeasure. People streamed towards the shop, not just adventurers and workers, but [Mages] as well!

Something was happening. Something big. People could feel it. Why else would the newly famed [Actors] all rush over to the shop and disappear

there? Why would Miss Agnes suddenly throw open her doors to her inn and announce drinks were on her for all the people helping to unload the wagons?

And what, in the name of the Five Families, did an *[Alchemist]* have to do with sending aid to Esthelm?

Some people knew, but most were out of the loop.

And that was only in Celum. In Liscor, the uproar was more like a furor in truth. The city had not turned out its warehouses to support a Human city, but it had commandeered every Runner, [Wagon Driver], [Rider], and transportation-based class that could be spared, all under the orders of the legendary Zel Shivertail himself.

Mages, drivers, runners, and a gaggle of adventurers milled about outside the city, shouting and being shouted at by a young woman who had developed quite the reputation in the city by now. A lot of the Drakes and Gnolls just resigned themselves to it; it was that crazy Human doing something weird again. But more stopped their work to watch the fun, and more still found themselves joining in when they heard what was going on.

Some were friends of Selys or part of Krshia's clan, and found themselves lending a paw, claw, or hand to help. Others were more impressed by the legendary Gold-rank adventurers and Zel Shivertail, and helped because he was lifting supplies effortlessly into wagons. Some just cared about Humans, as odd as it was.

But all that was a backdrop, meaningless babble to what was going on below. The Queen of the Free Antinium under Liscor sat in her throne room, staring down at the strangers standing before her.

The Antinium of four Hives stood before her, each one in their own group. The Prognugator Tersk, leading the three Armored Antinium who had come with him. Revalantor Pivr of the Flying Antinium and his cohort of six. Two soldiers of the Silent Antinium, almost invisible in the darkness. And Xrn, of the Centenium, now a Prognugator to the Grand Queen with her six bodyguards.

Of this group, it was only Xrn that the Queen of the Free Antinium was interested in, and only her that she respected. But annoyingly, it wasn't Xrn who was speaking right now.

"...And after my extensive surveying of your Hive, I have found only four of these so-called Individuals who have obtained formal designations. Moreover, they have not obtained any significant levels, Skills, or classes as

of yet. In my role as Revalantor for my Queen, I must ask whether this is truly an accomplishment that merits the attention of the Hives.”

Pivr’s voice echoed throughout the Queen’s chambers as all the Antinium stared at him. It was hard to read the other’s expressions, but the Queen felt they were getting annoyed by him. She certainly was.

His voice was higher in pitch than the other Antinium, and he moved about restlessly, fanning his wings when he stood still. Was he showing them off? The Queen had seen the true winged soldiers of the Antinium, long ago. She wasn’t impressed by the Queen of the Flying Antinium’s half-baked copies.

“So you have said. Repeatedly. But my achievement is extraordinary regardless of number. In fact, the rarity of such Individuals proves their worth. How many Prognugators does your Hive have, Pivr? How many Individuals has your Queen created?”

He ignored that question, as he had the ones before. Pivr seemed uniquely gifted at ignoring things he or his Queen didn’t want to see. As the Queen, so followed the Prognugator.

“I must simply ask how feasible the use of these Individuals is. Surely, if their creation is a workable method, you would seek to convert the entire Hive thusly? I ask, on behalf of my Queen, what formal plan you would put before the Hives.”

She *had* no formal plan, just this one accomplishment as the Queen of the Flying Antinium very well knew. The Queen of the Free Antinium tried to keep her temper, but it was hard.

She was angry the other Queens could not understand what they were doing, that they doubted her commitment to the Hives. She was angry that not all of them had sent their Prognugators to witness what she had done, that they questioned, or at least, didn’t trust that what she was doing was significant. She was also angry that Pivr was a pus-filled sack, and she was trying to restrain herself from ordering him killed—or just picking him up and crushing him herself.

The Queen tried to come up with a reply that didn’t include some form of violence, but she was distracted by another matter as well. Klbkch. Why wasn’t he here?

She *knew* he had returned to the Hive thirty minutes ago, but he had not come directly here, despite her mental summons. What was so important

that he would not help her get rid of Pivr, preferably by shoving a sword through the other Antinium's head?

To mask her irritation, the Queen turned her massive head towards Xrn. The female Antinium—the only one in the room besides the Queen—was standing still, her blue carapace shimmering slightly from the swirling lights reflected in her eyes. How beautiful.

The Queen knew she was the height of creation, an untouched remnant of the original Centenium forms, but she couldn't help but feel envious. She was so graceful, so perfect. She had been created to embody true perfection, not the flawed shells all the other Antinium here wore.

"What say you, Xrn of the Centenium? What opinion do you have of what has been created here?"

Pivr made a choked *clicking* sound from the side. But the Queen had addressed Xrn by her old title. It wasn't exactly correct, but that definitely put her authority far above a Revalantor's.

Xrn nodded slowly.

"I believe my Queen, the Grand Queen, will wish to explore what you have created a great deal further, oh Queen of the Free Antinium. At the very least, we will request one of the Individuals accompany us back to the Grand Hive to be appraised there. There is significance in this, even if the Individuals cannot be replicated on a large scale as of yet."

That sounded quite nice to the Queen of the Free Antinium. But she could sense Pivr getting ready for another comeback, probably to discredit her. She was just about ready to tell him he could go back to his Queen and tell her to eat all her eggs when she felt Klbkch approaching. She cut off Pivr with one feeler.

"Ah, I sense my Revalantor returns. Klbkchhezeim will answer any questions you may have, Pivr."

All heads turned towards the entrance. The Queen waited, hearing the faint footfalls growing louder. Klbkch strode into the room, twin sheathed swords swinging at his waist, light on his feet, slim.

So close to how he used to be. And yet, indescribably far away. The Queen watched Xrn react to Klbkch's presence. Tensely, and then relaxing. Yes, she felt it too.

This was more like the old Klbkch, the Slayer. But ah, it could never be him, not fully. His form was lost. Lost...

But he was hers, now. The Queen felt satisfaction in that. Klbkch stopped in front of the gathered Antinium and bowed to his Queen first, before nodding to them.

“My Queen, Antinium of the Hives, I must render you all my apologies. I was unavoidably detained last night, and was not able to meet with you as I had hoped.”

She could never be angry at him, not for long. The Queen waved a feeler graciously.

“Your absence was noted, but as always you work for the Hive’s greater good, Klbkchhezeim. All of the Hives.”

The Antinium nodded. He looked up at his Queen, and she felt the slightest thought pass between them. The Queen went still. What was he....?

“This is so. And I am aware of the scrutiny of the other Hives at this instance, so I have attempted to reveal much of where the true effort of our Hive has gone. In fact, I hope you will join me on a small expedition to demonstrate the true value of the Free Antinium of Liscor.”

What was this? The Queen didn’t speak to contradict Klbkch, but her mind was awlirl. Pivr turned to Klbkch, ready to pounce on any imperfections.

“Indeed, Klbkch? Your absence speaks to a lack of resources in the Hive. Could not an Individual have performed such tasks? What is this errand which will occupy a Revalantor of the Hive when he is needed elsewhere?”

Klbkch gave Pivr a look that made it clear the other Revalantor was not worth the syllables in his name. He turned to face the others, especially, the Queen thought, Xrn.

“The nature of the upcoming mission at hand is simple. I, as well as a group of one hundred and fifty Soldiers and twice that number of Workers, are travelling north to the Human city of Esthelm, escorting a convoy of supplies. We will be staying in the city for several days to provide aid to the citizens there.”

The Antinium did not waste time on shocked silence. Instead, they all spoke more or less at the same time. Pivr was the first. He exclaimed, spitting a bit of venom in surprise.

“What?”

Xrn next. Her voice was flat.

“What.”

Tersk, spreading his arms, open, honest.

“I do not understand.”

And the Queen. She couldn’t help it. The word slipped out.

“What?”

Fortunately, no one noticed. Tersk addressed Klbkch, speaking for the others.

“Revalantor Klbkch, I would ask that you explain your Hive’s reasoning for sending aid to this city. I see no immediate merit in such an action.”

Klbkch nodded. He ignored his Queen’s furious mental probes and explained to the other Antinium calmly.

“It is true that the benefits of such an act will not provide us with any immediate benefits. However, there are intangible benefits to such an act, and it costs the Hive very little in terms of resources. What we give will be repaid in the form of goodwill, trust, and friendship. Concepts which mean little to the other Hives, but which I...and my Queen...have grown to understand.”

She could *sense* the Workers and Soldiers in the Hive moving already! So that was what Klbkch had done! The Queen fumed, but she couldn’t gainsay him, not in front of the others. Why was he doing this? She didn’t understand, not one bit. Rendering aid without reward to a Human city not affiliated with the Hive? Why?

“I see. In that case, I will follow and observe, if you will permit it.”

Tersk nodded. The Queen supposed that was a victory, but she dearly wanted the Antinium to clear the room so she could have Klbkch explain to *her* what was going on. But Pivr was already talking again, refusing Klbkch’s offer.

“I will not. I will stay and observe this Hive, and perhaps see what dangers lurk in this dungeon which consumes so many resources. An expedition is not what I came here to witness.”

A pity. But, the Queen thought to herself privately, she might be able to organize it so a monster broke through and slaughtered Pivr by accident. The Flesh Worms were quite lethal, even when she deployed many Soldiers to counter them.

“I will go as well.”

Xrn spoke up, and the Queen saw Klbkch’s mandibles part and raise in an Antinium smile. She *really* didn’t like that, but it was too late to stop any

of them. She stared down at Klbkch.

“I wish you success on your task, Klbkch. Do not take too long, however. We have much to do...and discuss...when you return.”

He didn’t so much as flinch at the tone in her voice. Well, he wouldn’t. Klbkch bowed and left the room, leaving the Queen in the darkness to think.

And wonder.

“So tell me, is this what made you abandon our discussion last night and not return?”

Xrn’s tone was slightly acidic as she and Tersk—and their escort of lesser Antinium—followed him through the Hive. Klbkch nodded.

“There is merit in this, Xrn.”

“I understand that, even if your Queen and the others did not seem to. But I do not understand why *you* of all beings would see it.”

Klbkch made no answer. He clicked his mandibles together in embarrassment, the Antinium version of clearing his throat—although he could do that too.

“We will join up with the Antinium escort shortly. I have been specially approved by Liscor’s Watch Captain to take the force out of the city.”

“Oh? How exciting.”

“Yes. It is, in fact. As you will soon see. For this mission, I have chosen one of our newest Soldier units to escort the convoy. They are...uniquely prepared to foster goodwill and reduce alarm among the other species.”

That made Xrn pause, but she followed Klbkch out of one of the secret tunnels in the Hive and onto the snowy plain. The instant she and Tersk entered the sunlight they stopped and gasped.

All of the Antinium did. For a second, they paused and stared. Not because they hadn’t ever seen Soldiers before, but because they had never seen Soldiers like this.

Painted. Colorful. Some with every color of the rainbow—and several colors not of the rainbow—on their bodies, and some with only a few markings. But each one was unique. Distinct.

Individual.

Klbkch stopped next to Pawn, Belgrade, Anand, and Bird. They stood at attention, nervous, silent, in front of the ranks of Soldiers and Workers. Tersk and Xrn came forwards to inspect them.

“These are the Individuals? Well met.”

Tersk greeted the four. Belgrade, Bird, and Anand didn’t speak, but Pawn opened his mandibles until Klbkch shot him a look.

“These are Anand, Belgrade, Bird, and Pawn.”

“You did not introduce me to this Pawn before.”

Xrn spoke as she observed the Soldiers. Tersk had already moved past the Individuals, much to Klbkch’s relief. The armor-wearing Antinium’s voice was puzzled as he turned to Klbkch.

“Revalantor Klbkch, I am uncertain as to the reason behind decorating these Soldiers so. It seems to be a waste of resources.”

“Are you? I would assume the reason is obvious. They are Individual. Unique.”

Klbkch nodded to the Soldiers, not sure if he was lying or only telling a partial truth. Tersk’s breath caught and he closed his mandibles slowly.

“I see. I see. This changes much.”

“Everything.”

Xrn walked past the Soldiers as they stood in perfect ranks. Klbkch knew their attention was on her; the azure body of the Small Queen was as striking as their paint. She too was like them; completely separate from the nameless mass of other Antinium.

“I take it you approve?”

“I love it.”

She turned to him, and Klbkch saw the swirling colors in her eyes grow brighter. He opened his mandibles in a smile.

“I shall apprise you of the decision to paint the Soldiers as we march. We shall proceed, unless there are objections?”

She shook her head.

“None. Let us go see what defines the Free Antinium.”

Later that day, the road leading from Liscor north to the Human lands was empty. Empty, that was, except for one vehicle.

The lone wagon rumbled slowly down the road. It was a familiar group sitting in it. Ceria, Erin, Yvlon, Ksmvr, and Termin all sat, eating a quick mid-day lunch as they headed north through the snowy landscape. Well, Erin, Yvlon, Ksmvr, and Termin sat. Ceria and Pisces were more comatose bodies slowly chewing their food as they lay in the back of the wagon on some crates.

“I’m just saying, it makes no sense! Why wouldn’t you want to go see your brother at all? I get that you don’t want him to be annoying and fuss over you, but you don’t *ever* want to see him?”

Yvlon sighed and brushed away some crumbs Erin had accidentally spat on her.

“The instant he finds me, he’ll try to take me back to our home, no objections. He’s not just protective. He’d never accept me being—crippled and continuing to adventure like this.”

“Oh. But he’s got your best interests at heart. What if your family could help? I mean, with your arms...?”

Erin gingerly indicated the fused metal and flesh on Yvlon’s forearms, but the woman shook her head.

“If our family had a potion or artifact that could regenerate bones or limbs, we wouldn’t be a minor house in Izril. We’re known for having an adventurer or warrior in each generation—and having the first letter in our names be ‘y’. That’s all.”

“Well, I guess I understand. But you can’t run from your brother forever.”

“I don’t need to. As soon as he gets word of a village in trouble he’ll drop everything and run off. He *is* a [Knight].”

“Huh.”

“Hold up, you lot. There’s something on the road ahead.”

Termin suddenly called out in alarm, and Erma and Fox stopped in their tracks as he halted the wagon. All the adventurers immediately sat up, but they relaxed when they saw what it was.

“That’s not a monster!”

Erin chortled as she pointed at the creature that had caused Termin to stop his wagon. It was a beaver, sitting in the middle of the road.

“It’s a beaver. Why are you afraid of a beaver, Termin?”

Termin glared at Erin as he pointed to the beaver.

“That’s no ordinary beaver, Miss! It’s a Fortress Beaver, not one of your cute little rodents. See how large it is, even from here? It could bite my wheels in two in one go and probably take your leg off if you angered it. And where there’s one, there might be more. I’m not risking my wagon or my horses if I accidentally agitate it.”

Erin looked again, frowning. Now that she thought about it, the beaver certainly did look...*big* from so far away. It would be up to her chest—maybe up to her neck if she got close. She gulped.

“Okay, don’t pet the beaver. Well, can’t we get rid of it?”

Both she and Termin turned to look at the adventurers. Yvlon shook her head.

“I’m not killing a beaver.”

“I volunteer—”

“No, no.”

Erin hastily pushed down Ksmvr’s hand and turned in her seat. She poked the person lying behind her.

“Ceria. Hey, Ceria.”

“Wuh?”

One of the two comatose bodies raised its head. Ceria looked pale and exhausted, drained from using up all her mana, but she managed to get up to stare at the beaver.

“Can you get rid of it? You can talk to animals, right? Can you get it off the road so Termin can keep going?”

The half-Elf glared in outrage at Erin.

“Dead gods. *Erin*. Just because I’m a half-Elf, doesn’t mean I...well, I *do*, but why do you always turn to me to—”

She looked around the wagon. Everyone was staring at her. Termin cleared his throat.

“Well, do you or don’t you? I don’t speak beaver.”

Ceria growled, and pushed herself up. Grouchily, she stood up and moved to the front of the wagon, grumbling under her breath.

“It’s not like I *want* to learn this stuff. Fine, I’ll get it to move.”

She cupped her hands and took a deep breath. Erin was expecting her to chitter to the beaver, or make whatever sound they made, but Ceria just started shouting. The beaver’s head turned as she yelled at it.

“*Hey you! Yeah, you! Piss off!*”

The Fortress Beaver stared as Ceria shouted at it. It seemed to think about what the half-Elf had said, and then waddled off of the road.

“There. Done.”

Ceria let her hands fall and turned. Everyone was staring at her, Erin with a betrayed look in her eyes. Ceria shrugged defensively.

“What? That’s how you talk to animals if you want them to move.”

She sat back down and Termin flapped his reins, shaking his head. Erin felt a rumbling on the ground and looked around.

“Hey, hurry up Termin. I think the others are catching up.”

The Fortress Beaver, which had considered going back to take a bite out of the wagon anyways, felt the rumbling and made itself scarce. A good thing too, because the army of marching Antinium would have squashed it flat if the sea of wagon wheels didn’t do that before them.

As Termin got his cart moving, carts appeared in the distance behind him. Carts driven by Humans, Gnolls, Drakes, and in one case, driving itself since the driver had fallen off but the horses kept going. Each one was loaded to the brim with food, supplies, and people. There were more than a hundred adventurers, [Guardspeople], and other experts such as [Healers], [Masons], [Hunters], and more who had come to aid Esthelm.

And marching to one side of the road came the Antinium. Rows upon rows of Workers, dragging primitive wooden sleds loaded with materials of their own—nails, wood, hammers, but no food since what they ate was disgusting—led by a group of Antinium including Pawn at the front.

Erin beamed as the massive group began to catch up. Termin had left with a good lead on the others, but everyone was moving fast. It wasn’t evening yet, and they were nearly at Esthelm!

“You’re lucky so many of these wagon drivers have movement Skills.”

Pisces commented to Erin as he raised his head from his bed in the wagon. Termin cackled.

“Luck’s got nothing to do with it, necromancer. Around here you either move fast or you get eaten by something sooner or later. A Skill like [Continuous Rolling] is common for all us folk.”

The necromancer sniffed.

“Well then, she was lucky you all decided the roads were safe. Why did you decide to take the journey, pray tell Mister Termin? Surely you are aware such a convoy would be at risk of being attacked? Why not travel with an army from Celum?”

“Hah! Any army the Human cities could put together wouldn’t be half as powerful as an army led by Zel Shivertail himself! Add two groups of Gold-rank adventurers to the mix, the famous Horns of Hammerad—not to mention the Antinium Soldiers, and the Goblin Lord himself would look twice before taking us on!”

Before Pisces could open his mouth again, Erin leapt up in her seat and nearly fell off the wagon.

“Oh look, look! I can see the city from here! Wow, it still looks terrible!”

Esthelm came into view, and as soon as their wagon approached, Erin heard people on the walls shouting. But as more wagons were spotted, the shouting grew confused, and then jubilant. People began cheering and streaming out of the gates before Termin’s wagon had gotten close—then they saw the Antinium and ran back into the city.

In the end, Erin drove up to the gates. The people of Esthelm didn’t exactly shut the gates, but they met her and the wagon at them. The [Soldier] who had met Erin and the Horns of Hammerad two days ago was there, with a group of armed men who looked incredulously at the approaching force. Erin waved down at Umbral excitedly.

“Hi! Remember me? Well, I came back and I brought a lot of stuff to help! And a lot of people!”

His jaw dropped.

“You? You’re that [Innkeeper]! But how did—”

“It’s supplies and a relief force! From Celum *and* Liscor! And the Antinium! They’ve come to help fix your walls and guard your city!”

“The Antinium? *Here?*”

He seemed unable to process it all. Erin jumped down from the wagon and then sat down hard. Her legs had gone to sleep.

“Ow. Um. Well, it’s a long story, but these Antinium are really nice. They’ve brought a lot of stuff, and we have food, blankets, pillows, and so on. We even have—”

She got no further, because Umbral pulled her up and into a hug. Erin heard the cheering begin again as word began to spread.

“Aid has come to Esthelm!”

“Liscor! The Drakes have come to help us!”

“Esthelm is saved!”

Everyone was being thanked, except perhaps the Antinium. But Pisces summed it up best. He smiled, perhaps arrogantly, but with genuine pleasure at Umbral as the man let go of Erin. He nodded to the huge convoy and then at Erin.

“You may attribute this delivery to Erin Solstice, proprietress of the Wandering Inn. We can discuss remuneration for goods and services rendered at a later—”

He got no further than that, because Erin kicked him.

The city of Esthelm was saved. Only, it had already been saved. In a sense, you could say it was saved again, at least from the pressing needs of hunger, thirst, and the need for shelter. Pawn considered that this was less glamorous than saving the city from invading monsters, but no less necessary.

He stood in the ruined center of the city with his group of painted Soldiers, staring in awe at the buildings, the people, and the broken sewers that stank beyond belief. It was all new to him. He had never gone beyond Liscor, never seen so many Humans, or seen a city this badly destroyed. He knew his Soldiers hadn’t seen anything like this either, and he was glad to have shown it to them.

And yet, Pawn was also uncertain. Because while the others who had come seemed to know what they were doing, he did not. And that was a problem, because *he* was in charge of the Antinium here.

Klbkch had explained it to him quickly, which was to say confusingly, a few moments before they had left. Pawn was in charge because Klbkch had to deal with the Antinium from the other Hives. He had to speak with the Antinium in armor and the beautiful blue *female* Antinium for reasons unknown to Pawn. Thus, Pawn was in charge.

Which again, would be fine if Pawn knew what to *do*. But he didn’t. Oh, the Drakes, Gnolls, and Humans seemed well-organized enough. They were already unloading the wagons, the soldiers and guardspeople keeping order while carpenters, masons, and other groups split off to help aid the city. But Pawn was standing with over a hundred Soldiers and three hundred Workers in the middle of the city with not a clue of what to do now.

He badly wanted to go find Erin and ask, but Pawn realized that might not be an option right now. He had to do something. So he cleared his throat and looked around.

What could be done? Well, what *couldn't* be done? Pawn was no expert on cities, but he felt sure that walls shouldn't be falling down, there shouldn't be exposed sewers, and that Humans preferred a roof over their heads as they slept. He pointed randomly at a particularly bad section of the wall and turned to his sub-leaders, Belgrade and Anand.

"Our job is to assist in repairing this city. Thus, I think that wall is...a good place to start? Belgrade, Anand, if you will take that wall and uh, effect repairs on it? Reinforce it? Make it taller or something?"

"Certainly, Pawn."

"It will be done."

The two [Tacticians] nodded immediately and began walking towards the wall. Workers and Soldiers both streamed after them, making Pawn jump. Belgrade and Anand needed no spoken instructions to command the Soldiers. Somehow, they'd learned the trick of Prognugators, to command without speaking, mind-to-mind.

Well, that was easy. Pawn turned and nearly had one of his hearts stop when he found Bird standing right in front of him. The Antinium seemed... focused as he held a bow in his hands. An arrow was already nocked.

"There are many birds here. I must go hunt them."

"Oh? Certainly, Bird. Go ahead. Ah, be sure to bring the birds back so they may be eaten, alright?"

"Yes."

Bird hurried off, already staring at the sky. Pawn turned around, and then around, and realized everyone had left. Belgrade and Anand were already having Soldiers clear the rubble while Workers moved about preparing tools and forming neat rows to expedite the workflow.

Now Pawn felt lonely. He thought about what he should do next, and remembered something Erin had told him last night. He looked around, saw a familiar tail, and hurried towards it.

"I see what you mean. I see it."

Zel Shivertail muttered to himself as he walked through the city of Esthelm, gazing at the destruction. He felt a small pang in his heart as he saw how much devastation had been done, but the rest of him just felt mystified.

Why was he here? How had he come to be here, in Esthelm, helping to distribute aid to the citizens? He could have sworn he was eating rolls with honey just this morning.

It was all because of that girl. Erin Solstice. It hadn't been a unique idea, to help Esthelm. Anyone with at least one heart would have thought of that. And it wasn't hard to think of a door being used to transport things like goods. That was an obvious use. But convincing two cities to send supplies and help, and asking the Antinium, the *Antinium* no less to render assistance?

"...Who is she?"

That was what Zel Shivertail asked himself. He could admit when he'd misjudged someone. He'd done that with Erin Solstice. He still kept part of his original opinion, but now he revised the rest. Something was off about that girl. Something was extremely off, in a way he could only attribute to one other Human before...

"Excuse me, General Shivertail?"

Zel turned. He expected to see one of the Drakes, asking for him to sign his tail or something silly like that, or a Human, asking for help. But he froze when he saw the Antinium standing meekly in front of him.

Instinct told Zel to rip the Ant's head off. He restrained himself—with effort. Zel growled as he took a few steps back.

"What do you want?"

The Antinium nodded politely.

"My name is Pawn."

"You have a name?"

Zel was incredulous. But he caught himself—this was one of the new Antinium, the ones all the damn Drake politicians and leaders were telling him to find out about. Pawn nodded.

"I do. I ah, have been sent to aid in restoring Esthelm."

"Good. For you."

Zel didn't want to talk with any Antinium, even a new one. But Pawn clearly wanted to talk with him. The Antinium cleared his throat nervously.

“I was hoping I might converse with you, General Shivertail. I understand you are a famous General among the Drakes—”

“I fought in the Antinium War. *Both* Antinium Wars.”

“I know.”

The two stared at each other. Zel forced his fist to unclench. Pawn studied him carefully.

“I am not hostile towards you, General Shivertail. I do not wish to offend you either. I simply wish to talk.”

“Yeah? Well, I don’t want to talk to you.”

Zel forced himself not to shout. Pawn tilted his head sideways.

“May I ask why?”

“You’re an Antinium. I saw your kind ravage my continent. You still do. You infest part of my home. I saw your Soldiers slaughter thousands of innocents.”

“Yes. They did. But I was created long after those wars. I am not like my people. I am not like anyone.”

There was something in the Antinium’s eyes—Zel looked away. He controlled his voice, spoke levelly.

“Look, An—Pawn. I came here to help the Humans here, because it was the right thing to do. Because it was a good cause, understand? And I tolerated your Hive sending an army here, though I’d rather kill you all, because you lot are helping too. I won’t pick a fight with your kind, but it doesn’t mean I have to like you, or talk with you. I lost too many friends, too many comrades to your species to ever think of you as anything but the enemy. Understand?”

Silence. And then Zel saw Pawn nod out of the corner of his eye.

“I understand. But I did not come here to be friends. I came to ask—you see, I have been placed in command of my own force. I am a...leader. But I do not know how to lead.”

“So? The Antinium lead themselves, or the Queens do, don’t they?”

“Yes, but she has entrusted that role to me. I must lead, but I do not know how. That is why I have come to you. You are a Drake [General], one of the greatest leaders on this continent.”

Zel Shivertail stared incredulously at Pawn.

“You want me to give you...*advice* on how to lead an army?”

Pawn nodded.

“Yes.”

“Why in the name of the Ancestors would I do that?”

The Antinium shrugged. He seemed at a loss in front of Zel’s questioning stare.

“I do not know. I simply hoped you would. Because you understand the burdens of leadership.”

Zel turned away in disgust.

“I’ve never taken on a pupil. If you want to ask for training, go find Niers Astoragon, or some Human [Lord] like Lord Tyrion Veltras.”

“They are far away.”

“I don’t care.”

Zel turned to go. Pawn called out behind him.

“One question, please. Answer me one question, General Shivertail.”

General Shivertail gritted his teeth and lashed his tail.

“If I do, will you go away and stop bothering me from now on?”

“Yes.”

“Fine. Ask.”

Pawn was silent for a moment. Zel was about to snap when the Antinium spoke.

“What do you tell a soldier under your command when he is dying?”

The world paused. Zel turned back. Pawn went on.

“You see, I do not know what to say. I can only hold them, but I do not know what is supposed to be said. But there must be something. What do you say?”

The Drake stared at the Antinium. Down at the Antinium. He realized that Pawn was small. He wasn’t a Soldier. He was a Worker, no fighter. He didn’t even have a weapon at his side. For a second, Zel wrestled with himself, and then one part won. He sighed, and gingerly beckoned Pawn.

“Come on. Walk with me.”

Pawn hesitated, but then followed Zel. The Drake stared up at the sky, at the Antinium swarming over a wall and putting it back together bit by bit, and at the Humans, Drakes, and Gnolls all working together in this city. Because of a girl. Because of an innkeeper. And he walked side by side with an Antinium and told him what to say, what you could say, what you had to say when you held a soldier in your arms.

“You tell them this. You tell them they did a good job, that they can rest. That you’ve never seen anyone fight that hard, that it’s only a scratch. That it’s going to be okay—”

“Even if it is not?”

“Especially then. You tell them what they need to hear. And sometimes, what they need to hear is nothing. Sometimes you just hold their claw and say goodbye. Sometimes...”

Klbgkch saw Pawn walking next to Zel Shiverail and couldn't believe his eyes. He almost didn't believe Xrn's, but she had seen it too.

“What a strange thing.”

That was all she said. She hadn't said much, just taken in everything on the march to Esthelm. Klbgkch got the impression Xrn was saving up all her words for when she'd sorted out her feelings. Guiltily, he was looking forward to her reaction when it all came out.

But for now, Klbgkch just walked with Tersk and Xrn through Esthelm, explaining things for the other two Antinium, but Tersk mainly. Klbgkch kept having to pause and stare at the people working, though. He felt a little twinge in his chest every time he saw a Human look up, jump at the sight of him, and then gingerly wave, or at the very least, not flee screaming.

They came to an open square, where the smell of cooking was making Klbgkch long for dinner already. He had already explained to the others that they would be eating Human, Drake, and Gnoll foods on this expedition—this seemed to have raised their morale quite a bit.

But now Klbgkch saw Erin, standing in the center of the square, next to a grave blooming with flowers and a rather tall stone marker, speaking energetically to a small group of Humans, two Gnolls, and a Drake. She had found a [Flautist], a man with a crude bell that was probably used to sound the alarm, a man holding a harp, and a group of people who could sing.

“Revalantor Klbgkch, what is that group of people doing?”

Klbgkch paused. He was unsure, although he thought he knew.

“I think they're—”

All at once, Erin broke into song. She sang loud and clearly, startling everyone around her. They stared at her as the girl started singing a song that Ryoka Griffin would have recognized instantly.

“Dashing through the snow, in a one-skeleton open sledge, o'er the fields we go, screaming all the way! Bells on Gnoll-tails ring, making spirits bright...”

She gestured, and the man with the bell began hitting it rhythmically. The Antinium watched as Erin tried to teach the rest of the appropriated lyrics to the others. He could hear her shouting.

“Come on, you don’t know this song? It’s famous! Don’t tell me you guys don’t have *Christmas!*? I’ve got so much to teach you all! Alright, on three, okay? One, two...”

“Revalantor Klbkch, I do not understand. What is the purpose of this?”

Tersk whispered it to Klbkch as the group began to sing. Klbkch heard the melody drifting throughout the city, caught by a breeze of wind. It was such a simple song, and yet it had a power of its own. People began to hum the song, or join in after a few repetitions.

“What confuses you, Prognugator Tersk?”

“What is the purpose of such an activity? Could not these people aid in some other task to better effect?”

“Perhaps. But this is important too. It will inspire others to work faster. And...it has a value of its own.”

“Which is?”

Revalantor turned his face up to the sky as the music began to spread. He smiled, and wished he could close his eyes. He could not, so he just said one word.

“Listen.”

3.35

In the city of Esthelm there was a slime. It oozed along the ground, leaving a trail as it went. It was a slime, a round little pebble of liquid with no real defining features besides its dark greenish brown insides, which pulsed as it moved.

But it *was* a slime, and as of such it attracted a young woman who followed it as it slowly roamed across the broken rubble of the city. Erin Solstice stared, captivated by the tiny slime. It was like a small puddle come to life, and it looked incredibly cute to her, even if she was inhaling a noxious odor from the nearby sewer.

She wanted to touch it. Erin was vaguely aware that even the cutest of monsters could be dangerous, but she assumed that a truly dangerous creature would have been destroyed on sight. So a touch wouldn't hurt, right? She reached out to touch it.

Above the city of Esthelm there was a herd of faeries. They held their breath as Erin reached out.

“Erin! Don't touch that!”

Someone shouted at the girl and the faeries released their breath in a collective sigh of disappointment. They watched as a half-Elf ran over to Erin, scowling. Erin turned, looking hurt.

“What? Why not?”

“Erin, you can't just go around touching monsters—especially *slimes!*”

“Why? It doesn't look that dangerous! What, is it acid or something?”

“Don't be insane. *Acid* slimes? Dead gods, Erin, what a thought! No, this one is...look, do you know what slimes are? How they're made?”

“Noooo....”

“It's very simple.”

Ceria took a step back, pulling Erin away from the slime. It had begun rolling towards them, more inquisitively than with any real hostility. The half-Elf made a face.

“Look, slimes are...well, they’re closer to Golems than anything else, although they *are* alive. Actually, they’re closer to jellyfish. Um. Do you know what those are?”

“Of course I do!”

Erin looked insulted. Ceria shrugged.

“Some people have never seen the sea before. Anyways, slimes breed or spawn in bodies of liquid when the conditions are right. I guess some mana potions broke, or there were some already but—Erin, they take on the properties of their original liquid, get it? And this one clearly came from the sewer.”

The watching faeries saw Erin take a second to piece this together. Then they heard her horrified exclamation.

“Wait, you mean this is a *poo slime*? Aw!”

They laughed as she practically ran away from the small slime. It wasn’t as satisfying as if she’d stuck her hand in it—or if she’d fallen and put her face in the slime—but it would have to do.

The faeries flew across the city, pointing out more amusing sights for each other as they went. Esthelm was full of activity and four different species all trying to work together, which was a highly amusing sight for the watching fae.

That they didn’t swoop down and cause havoc or play tricks was perhaps the only sympathy the fae had to the people of Esthelm. At the moment they were content to simply be amused at mortal antics. What truly revealed their soft hearts though, was the fact that it had stopped snowing over Esthelm, even though fat snowflakes were falling several hundred meters away.

The fae loved children, sweets, mortal fools and heroes, and tricks. Other things too of course, but those were fairly universal aspects among their

kind. Only a few, the old or the odd, liked actually interfering with the fates to any real degree.

Ivolethe didn't like to meddle in mortal affairs, let alone Human, but she was of the mind it had to be done. And while she could watch Erin throwing rocks at the sewer slime forever, she reluctantly decided it was time.

She chattered to her fellow faeries and flew off. She had a mission, or rather, a cause. It wasn't necessarily fun, but she knew it was important. The reason and end was important, even if the doing of it was a pain.

So the faerie flew away from Esthelm to a far more boring place. She flew up and up, and then sideways, and then in a direction not describable by words. Ivolethe flew through part of the world, and then flew through the air in the world and out of an empty bit of space behind a few books in a bookshelf. She sneezed and grumbled, brushing off dust from her wings as she circled the room.

It was a very large room, and very grand too, although decorations had been forgone for a more austere, solemn appearance. This was a library, and the towering bookcases were imposing, despite the rich wood that made up their frames. The books were all first-edition, spotless, and magical too. Ivolethe flew by them, seeing the spells worked into the bindings to keep the pages from dirt or harm.

And in that room sat a girl. She was Asian, dark haired, slightly darker of skin than most Humans on this continent, and taller than most Human females, if not Drake or Gnolls. She was athletic, her body toned, and could be considered attractive. Ivolethe personally thought Ryoka looked far too Human, but she had some affection for her ugly friend.

But that affection ended when she saw Ryoka was *still* reading. The girl was sitting in a chair, knees drawn to her chest, flipping through a large and rather heavy tome whose pages looked like they had been gilded with gold. The girl did not notice Ivolethe flying towards her at all.

"Stop reading, ye daft cow!"

Ivolethe screamed in Ryoka's left ear. The girl jumped and tried to get out of the chair and twist simultaneously. The chair rocked backwards and she hit the ground.

"Ivolethe! *Damn it*, don't do that!"

Ryoka swore as she picked herself up. She reached for the book and made sure it wasn't damaged before she glared at the faerie. But the little Frost Faerie was full of far more wrath than Ryoka; she buzzed around the young woman, shouting angrily.

"Put down that book, fool! Go outside and *do something*! 'Tis been forever and a day since you decided to stay here; stop dawdling and act!"

Ryoka scowled. She put the book back on the table and turned to it.

"It's been only a few days. Okay...maybe more, Ivolethe. That's not forever. Leave me alone and let me read, will you?"

"Forever is a thought, not a number, fool. And I will not let ye waste away! There are things to be doing! Anything is better than staring at dusk and dead leaves and ink of the past!"

Ivolethe sneered at Ryoka as she hovered in front of the girl's face, getting in the way of the text. Ryoka swatted at her; Ivolethe danced aside and flew back in the way, impossible to touch.

"Fine. Let me just finish this passage and I'll go. Happy?"

The faerie scowled and crossed her arms. She blew a stream of icy air upwards, but then acquiesced less than gracefully.

“If ye must. But promise to put aside the book! Promise it!”

Ryoka rolled her eyes, but she did promise. It was an oath made to a faerie, and she would not break that lightly.

“I will be done in thirty minutes. Is that enough?”

Ivolethe shook her head.

“One!”

“Twenty.”

“One!”

“Ten minutes, okay?”

“Well...fine. But hurry up!”

Ryoka sighed as Ivolethe floated back over to the bookshelves, to go see if Erin had found the dead raccoon corpse that was bobbing in the open sewer main. The young woman turned back to the book, frowning as she lost herself for a few more minutes in the tightly-written scrawl of words.

It had been over a week since the attack on Magnolia’s mansion. A week, and Ryoka had not left yet for Invisil. Because she had had a thought. And that thought was...

I really don't like faeries. I mean, okay, they're nice to be around sometimes, and they're wondrous beings of nature and otherworldly marvels and yadda yadda, etc. But they don't read. I don't even think they keep written records; they were around far before the invention of such things, after all.

So they have no patience at all with reading, except I guess if it's about them. I can imagine a bunch of faeries finding a book about King Arthur or the fae. But they are like children in some respect.

Noisy, angry children who can turn a library into a blizzardy hell if they get bored.

Yes, I'm in Magnolia's mansion. Yes, it's been a week since she was attacked. The assassins are all dead, everyone's patched up—hell, all the damage in the courtyard was gone the next day and I'll just bet her sitting room is as perfect as it used to be. Magnolia and Ressa left the day after the attack, heading farther north to her estates.

She left me with promises of assistance, subtly dire threats, and Reynold. Apparently he'll be my guide in Invril, which will open some doors I guess. I could go check out the city and get all I need done at any time; hell, I can even take the carriage since I'm going with Reynold. Apparently that's the second-hand one; Magnolia went off in her personal vehicle which can probably fly and shoot lasers. There's no one stopping me from leaving.

And yet, I'm still here. Yeah, that's sort of surprising, but the reason I stayed is simple enough. Or rather, it's a mix of reasons.

One. I don't have to go to Invril...at least, not to get some good work done. The best thing about being in a mansion full of [Butlers] and [Maids] and [Manservants] is that you can get them to do things. Like haul a bunch of artifacts over to the most reputable [Enchanter] in the city to get them appraised. Magnolia even suggested that bit; she's willing to foot the not-inconsiderable bill to get them looked at, although I'll have to be the one to pay for any repairs or what have you. I guess she wants to know what Ceria and the others found.

As for all the deliveries, well, they can wait. A week of waiting for their delivery is still a lot faster than you could ask for, especially since they're coming all the way from Remendia and because no one else was doing the run.

Right, so I don't have to leave the mansion. But why would I want to stay? The answer's simple for me, and I realized it the moment I saw Magnolia heading off in her carriage. When the cat's away, the mouse has got to play*. Or in this case, the runner girl gets to poke around in her private home and find out all of her dirty little secrets.

*Damn it, I don't want to be a mouse. How about a rat? I could live with being a rat.

...Anyways. I failed on that venture. Polite servants get less polite the more intrusive you get, it seems. And while Ressa the ninja-maid is gone, Magnolia's got some scary maids. The Gnoll one is especially intimidating.

So I failed to pry, but then I remembered that Magnolia has something else which is priceless: books. Frickin' *books*. To be more accurate, a library, which is *not* a common convenience in this world.

And she's one of the most powerful women in the world. And this is her personal library. How could I not spend some time here figuring out, well, *everything*? My god, there's probably more pieces of the puzzle of this world in this room than anywhere else. And...

Yeah. It's sort of boring trying to do research here. I won't lie. Ivolethe has a point. It's been a week. I've skimmed through over a hundred books at least, and read from dawn till dusk. I want to burn down this entire library and never read a word of cursive again. If I find the asshole who thought curly writing was a good idea...

At least I have a way to read the books. I push back the pair of bulky lenses over my eyes as I peer at the book in front of me, trying to make the script out. I need these glasses, as ill-fitting and heavy as they are; they're magical and can translate the multitude of languages in these books.

But somehow, they still don't translate weird handwriting. I swear, this was written by someone with two left hands. Which, considering the species in this world, might not be too far off.

“In the fall of the Strygian Empire we find peace for a time. And yet, the dead still rise from every grave and haunt the few souls still living. Something still calls them back, and Ghouls are but the least of the undead who continue to reanimate. Fifteen Wraiths wiped out a village in one night, and I fear that the curse of the Untombed One still lingers on our land...”

Heavy stuff. I've got a pile of history books around me, and I'm currently reading through an account of some empire which fell a few thousand years back around these parts. I flip past that section. As fascinating as the history might be, I've read countless stories like this one.

The history of this world is...vast. As far as I can tell, some accounts claim that civilization was flourishing even twenty thousand years ago. That's incredible. You'd think that such a world would have entered into a modern or post-modern age, or at least come up with some sort of industrial revolution by now. And yet—

When you read through the accounts of histories, skipping past the triumphal bullshit and the rewritten bits that make out each [King] as the one true savior and so on, it's a simple picture.

War dominates this world. War, and little else. Each record is the same. War. Peace. War again, after a few decades or just a year. A border conflict between two grand nations escalates; proxy wars break out in five different nations. War drags in an entire continent into war; a second continent begins to fight that one. War. An armistice is declared. More war.

War.

Few nations have the time to develop properly, I guess. Well, they might reach new technological heights, but that's by this world's standards, which means it generally comes in the form of mage-powered inventions, not science and steel. But in time, each nation or city will eventually find themselves fighting a battle to the death with someone else.

It's not Human nature. It's the nature of all these species. That's the issue, as I see it. There are countless species in this world and while one species might be content with peace, the others are angry, touchy, prideful, jealous bastards who'll attack if they think things are unfair, which is, of course, always.

And yet, by the same token, there's never an end to the cycle, never a victor because it's too hard. This world is far larger than our own; huge nations the size of the United States or Russia are normal countries around here, or even small. Forging a large empire that would put an end to wars by conquering everything in sight always fails due to a number of factors.

The first is size. It's too hard to expand and keep supply lines going. Too, a larger nation faces a much greater risk of internal strife or dissent from within. And even if a nation gets a proper transport system and bureaucracy running, such empires usually fail simply because the [Emperor] or [Warlord] gets old and dies.

You can't conquer the world in one lifetime, not here. And that's the rest of the twist of this world; nations live and die by their rulers, not like the ones back at home. All the power of a high-level [King], well, once it's gone a country is easy pickings.

The second factor, then, is probably levels. No nation can ever stay on top just by being bigger. They might have better gear, better training, better economy, but once a high-level individual pops up, even a tiny nation can turn into a powerhouse. Small rebellions that are easily suppressed turn into full-scale revolts as some [Peasant] becomes a [Hero].

Yeah. There were heroes, once. It's a rare class, but apparently it does exist. I've read countless books, pored through them for useful details. One of the things I learned? There is a [Hero] class, even if none of the historians writing the books knows how it can be obtained.

And third? Technology in this world is not the same as in mine. In mine, people build industry and create ideas and inventions that can be built upon, permanent infrastructure like assembly lines and the technology to build steam engines. In this world?

Magic rules. But the problem with that is when an empire dependent on magical innovations loses all of its high-level mages, everything goes right back to the start. If they built huge factories and used machines perhaps the world would change. But I see how easy magic is to use. You can create a carriage that can outrun any vehicle from our world with magic. Hell, it could probably outrun anything but the *Shinkansen* bullet trains. But you can't create a hundred, or a thousand. And once the mage who made it dies, so too does the means of creating it.

Stagnation.

The other things I've learned? I push the book back and sigh. Ivolethe's coming back any time now and I'm not feeling too keen on hearing how the Strygian Empire crumbled away. Let's do a refresher.

"Important things...important things? One. There are no gods. Ever."

No mention of them. Not one, in over ten thousand years of history, as far as I can tell. It's hard to figure out the chronological order of the books; they use a dating system based on events, so eras come and go fast. It's damn annoying, and finding a reference book to make sense of it all is a challenge in itself.

But like I said, no mention of gods. Not once, in thousands of years. Oh, there are hints—references to someone trying to bring back the [Cleric] class, a faded relic here and there, but no gods are ever referenced directly. They're dead. I wonder why no new ones were ever made? It's such a discrepancy I can't quite believe it.

"But that aside—Rhir. It's always at war. And the Antinium are new."

Really new. In this millennium new; in this century new, in fact. They just popped up out of nowhere, and that's odd for Rhir.

Or not. Rhir is a scary place. The more I read about it, the more it seems it's *always* been at war. There's always a Blighted King or Queen, or Blighted Princes...it's always fighting against some threat or other.

"But it changes. It damn well changes. The Demons are new, too."

Five thousand years back they emerged, catching a prosperous set of kingdoms off-guard. But they should have expected it, even though they had several hundred years of peace to grow complacent. Because Rhir is always at war.

Sometimes they fight off the enemy—it can be races of any kind. There’s a reference to a Blighted Princess holding off a marauding army of twisted horrors with no real name, but there’s always *something*. The kingdoms of Rhir, or kingdom in this case, is always fighting a battle. Sometimes they win. Sometimes they lose and the horrors spread across the world.

Huge armies from every corner of the world have come to take back Rhir. They slaughter the monsters, take back the lands, put a nation back there. Everything is peaceful. And then...

I go back to one of the open books on the table, find the passage.

“The continent is secure. The last of the tide of Crellers has been purged, although the other nations report infestations in their lands from time to time. Yet Rhir remains safe, apart from a few disturbances reported in underground mining incidents each year. However, infestations of monsters are put to the sword the instant they are uncovered...”

And then? Black slime pops out, begins mutating everything around it, and this kingdom gets destroyed. I wish I could say I’m making this up. But there’s something in Rhir that keeps creating new things to destroy with.

Something. A dead God. Like Klbkch said.

I shiver. How could no one have known? Well, they did know. People can figure out when something’s wrong. After they fought back the evil slime stuff, a huge army made up of soldiers from three damn continents went underground, searching for the root of their problems. None of them made it back, but one year later a bunch of abominations made from parts of people came out and slaughtered everyone.

What’s the lesson here? Avoid Rhir.

I push the book back, feeling vaguely sick. Ivoethe is right. There are no answers here. Just more things to keep me up at night. If there’s any consolation I have, it’s knowing a bit more about the world.

I knew a lot, or enough, rather. Five main continents. Rhir, Izril, Terandria, Chandrar, and Baleros. Each one with different species, although Humans are on all the continents in some form or other. But it's the major world powers that are interesting. Aside from the various nations, there are some standouts, some big players.

One of the ones I didn't know about are the Slave Traders of Roshal. It's apparently a city, or an empire that keeps itself neutral. It's based in Chandrar and it's about as powerful as Wistram, although it's actually neutral, rather than political like the mages.

Also, the Minotaurs have an archipelago. They feud with other nations—hell, they tried to take over the world a few times, although almost every species has done that over the course of the world. They usually go to war with a bunch of mysterious foreigners—I never found a book about them, but they might be like my world's version of Japan, or the Philippines. They live at the 'edge of the world'.

So this world has an edge? Or have people still not figured out that the earth is round? *Is it round?* I can assume nothing here.

What else? There are Dwarves. Good to know. They live on Terandria, although they used to be everywhere. There used to be harpies, actual intelligent ones with a nation of their own. They're dead. There used to be a people like djinn—highly magical, part spirit. They're dead. There used to be undead kingdoms. They're gone.

There used to be Elves, but every reference in the books I've read only talks about *half*-Elves. When did the Elves die out?

Don't know. But the Dragons are mostly dead, too. Every few thousand years one gets slain, but the occurrence of such entries grew less and less the more I read. I guess, in a sense, this world *is* stabilizing. In that species are dying. Perhaps someday, after countless thousands of years, it might be only one or two species left.

Maybe it'll be Goblins. Because no matter how many times they get wiped out, they always come back. And the reports of what happens when a Goblin King emerges...

I read the book Magnolia told me about, the one about the Second Antinium Wars. Yeah. There were no winners in that war, but it was clear that it was more like the ‘Goblin wars where the Antinium, Az’kerash, and everyone else barely manage to beat him while fighting with each other’.

So much for historical accuracy. I rub at my temples. I have a headache. Is there anything else...?

“You said you would stop reading!”

The accusatory voice makes me look up. Ivoethe glares at me. I push the book back.

“I’m done.”

The faerie glares and points. A bit of frost covers the pages of the books. Just a bit; Ivoethe’s magic is apparently very weak inside, even if the library doesn’t have much iron in it.

“Now ye are. Come on! Time to leave this stuffy place! I crave adventure!”

“I crave a sub sandwich.”

I mutter as I leave the room. I feel old as I walk through Magnolia’s grand estate, passing by servants who make way for me. I feel old, out of place.

Like an intruder.

It’s still only been a few days since the attack. I’m the only other person in the mansion not in Magnolia’s employ—I did ask about the other people from our world that Erin met, but I got no answers. I’m the odd one out, and I feel it.

Out of the corner of my eye I see a bevy of maids and a man in a black suit coat hurry into the library. They’ve got a lot of reshelving to do. Do I feel

guilty about that?

Only slightly.

Ivolethe flies happily through the corridors of the mansion, making people duck out of the way or hurry to one side. She seems to feel safe inside here, so long as Magnolia isn't around, that is. And she quite enjoys terrorizing the people here.

In fact, one of her favorite targets is just up ahead. Ivolethe smiles widely as she spots him eating through one of the glass windows. I try to stop her, but it's too late. I sigh and head outdoors. As I do, I smile, just a bit. Today I will go to Invrakil. Reading's all very well, but I guess I'm just an active sort of person.

And I wouldn't mind a bit of adventure myself, come to that.

Reynold the [Butler] was eating outdoors, despite the nip in the air. That was because eating indoors where he could get crumbs on the floors would get him in quite a bit of trouble with those assigned to cleaning. Right now he was enjoying a skewer of meat, still steaming in the cold air.

It wasn't a very Human dish, but the people of Izril had adopted the foods of other species. This was a favorite food of Drakes, and it had spread across the continent. The kebab could have used some vegetables for flavoring, but Reynold had been late to lunch and only managed to snag one of the extras.

Still, the meat was hot, juicy, and Reynold was content to eat as he stood against one wall in the mansion. He was happy in life. That was, until he spotted the blue patch of indistinct light coming towards his face at speed.

Reynold ducked as the Frost Faerie flew past his head. But it wasn't him that the faerie was after. He felt a tugging at the skewer in his hand and to his dismay, saw two chunks of meat disappear upwards into the air.

Reynold watched in silent misery as the faerie began to devour a good bit of his meal.

“Ivolethe! Damn it, I told you not to steal food from people! Or at least don’t make it obvious when you’re doing it!”

An angry voice rang out in the small courtyard. Reynold sighed. So much for enjoying his lunch in peace. He turned and put on a polite smile as his profession dictated.

“Good evening Miss Ryoka. I trust this day sees you well?”

“Hey Reynold.”

The tall young woman jogged over, pausing to stop in front of Reynold. She glared at the orb of blue light Reynold thought of as a Frost Faerie, a force of nature rather than an actual being. But Ryoka could apparently see such creatures, and talk to them. Reynold had spotted this particular faerie indoors, and he had been flabbergasted to see the true identity of these beings.

That still didn’t make him any less wary of them, though. Reynold eyed the fuzzy patch of light as it swooped closer to his meal. He would have given it up rather than risk the faerie’s wrath, but Ryoka swiped at the Frost Faerie, making it dodge away.

“Stop that. Leave the poor man to his meal. I’ll buy you something to eat when we get to Invril, okay?”

“Ah, so you are planning on visiting the city today?”

Reynold straightened up as the faerie flew back towards Ryoka. She nodded towards him, distracted. She stared at the faerie and scowled.

“What? Why do I...? He can’t even see you properly, why the hell should—okay, fine, fine. Shut up.”

She turned back towards him with a resigned look on her face. Ryoka pointed towards the hovering faerie’s indistinct form.

“Ivolethe is here. She wants to be acknowledged.”

“Of course. My deepest apologies, Miss Ivolethe.”

Reynold bowed in the direction of the faerie, according her the respect and proper tilt of the back due to a member of an aristocratic house. He couldn't hear her of course, but Reynold got the impression the faerie was pleased.

"Glad you enjoyed that. Okay Reynold, I'm ready to go. One or two questions before we go, though. You said you brought all of the artifacts to an [Enchanter]. Any word on whether it's done?"

"The estate has not received any communications to that effect, Miss. However, I am sure you could visit the mage in person to ask."

"I might do that. Okay, next question. Are your orders to show me around the city, or can I only count on you for the ride back?"

Reynold answered carefully, remembering all the things Ressa had told him to say—and not to say.

"I am at your disposal, Miss Ryoka. I will accompany you as long as is needed—within Invrisil. I am not permitted to escort you anywhere outside of the city and my help is limited to an, ah, advisory role."

"Meaning you don't step in if I'm in trouble?"

Reynold winced.

"That is broadly correct, Miss."

"Well, that's fine. Okay, last question."

Ryoka stepped forwards and was suddenly uncomfortably close to Reynold. She narrowed her eyes.

"Where are the others? The other people from my world."

The unfortunate [Butler] swallowed.

"I don't—"

"Don't lie to me. I know they were here. Erin told me. Where did they go?"

The man let the silence go on till the count of five. That seemed like enough time—Ressa had told him to pretend to be reluctant to tell Ryoka.

“They...are learning to become adventurers, Miss. I believe they have been escorted southeast of here to—to train.”

“Train? You mean Magnolia’s hauling a bunch of kids to—damn, that sounds just like her. Are they going to get killed?”

“I don’t believe so, Miss. They have competent escorts.”

“But knowing Magnolia, they won’t step in unless someone’s about to die.”

Ryoka shook her head. She eyed Reynold and he wondered if she was going to ask him where they were—that was something he couldn’t reveal. To his relief, she seemed to abandon the idea.

“I don’t need to see them anyways. The city’s what I’m concerned about. Why don’t we head over there?”

He nodded, relieved.

“I will have the carriage prepped and ready to go within five minutes, Miss. If you will follow me?”

“I don’t need a carriage. I’ll run to the city and meet you inside. At the Runner’s Guild, say.”

The [Butler] hesitated.

“I’m not sure that would be the most efficacious use of time, Miss Ryoka.”

She stared at him.

“First, stop calling me Miss Ryoka. I’ve told you that. I don’t care what your [Butler] protocol says. Second, *why* would that take a long time?”

“The [Guardsmen] at the gates do a thorough check of all visitors entering the city, Mi—ah, Ryoka. The queue moves fairly quickly, but it would be easier to take Lady Reinhart’s carriage. Her servants and associates are never stopped on their errands.”

“The privilege of power, huh?”

Ryoka snorted and shook her head.

“It doesn’t matter how long the line is, Reynold. I’m a Runner. I skip the waiting around at the gates.”

“Not in Invril. Customs apply to all people entering, even Runners. There is a separate line, but...”

“What, they check Runners too? Why? Don’t tell me they’re at odds with their Runner’s Guild.”

“Not as such. But Invril sees far more magical artifacts and potentially dangerous items entering and leaving the city than most locations. Prudence is necessary.”

“They really get that many deliveries that could be dangerous? What about the Runner’s claim to confidentiality? Don’t tell me they’d open all of my packages.”

“I believe they have spells for that. As for the rest, well, Invril is slightly...larger than you might be used to, Ryoka.”

Reynold smiled slightly and stroked his trim mustache to hide it. Ryoka gave him an arch look while Ivoethe flew around her head.

“We’ll see. Let’s take the carriage, then.”

Invril, the city of adventurers. It was one of the features of Izril, a place that would appear on any map of the world. Ryoka and Erin had both heard the city’s name during their stay in this world. It was a place of adventurers, the heart of the northern half of the continent, where Humans would come to find the strongest of adventurers, undertake the most dangerous of requests. And of course, visit one of the most prosperous cities on the continent.

After all, where adventurers thrived, there had to be a city of equal size and resources to support them. Inns and food to feed countless mouths, [Mages], [Alchemists], and [Blacksmiths] to supply warriors with any

number of aids in battle, and [Merchants] to buy and sell goods looted, [Guardsmen] to break up fights between rival parties, brothels, gambling pubs, enchanters and healers, trackers and cartographers, bards and laborers...

It was a city to rival any modern city from Ryoka and Erin's world. If the buildings weren't as tall as skyscrapers, well, many of them were far higher than normal architecture would allow thanks to magically reinforced walls. And if there were no cars or planes, there were enough carriages, coaches, wagons, and carts to make up for that.

But the rest was the same. In fact, the rest was even more than Ryoka had seen in places like New York City. For while that city could boast over eight million souls, each one was Human. Not so in Invisil.

String People walked down the street, chatting, poking at loose threads in each other's bodies right next to Drakes, who strode around, keeping their tails from being trodden on by impatient Minotaurs who towered even over the heads of the Gnolls in the crowd. Humans dominated the scene, but they walked cheek-by-heel with Selphids, did business with Drowned Men and Women, and argued hotly with bird-people, coughed as dusty travelers whose bodies seemed part sand walked past them—

Ryoka stared as the carriage drove down the streets, making good time despite the huge amount of people. Ivolethe, sitting on Ryoka's head, stared around in delight, laughing and pointing at individuals in the crowd. But Ryoka couldn't focus on any one thing.

The buildings! Some were made of wood and stone yes, but many had colored roofs in every shade, and still more had been painted or given artistic fronts. When magic could easily make any relief permanent, the most prosperous buildings paid for [Painters] and [Muralists] to create wondrous images. Ryoka saw a group of adventurers battling a hideously large Troll adorning three buildings, each one showing part of the complete relief. Then her eyes turned and saw the lights.

There was no electricity in this world. But who needed that when magic provided an even steadier, softer glow? The hanging orbs of crystal shone even in the day, and some had been enchanted to shift color steadily, to catch and bewitch the eye.

“See the guards on patrol, Miss Ryoka? They’re fine warriors, all of them. As fine as you’d see in any Drake city! Some of them are retired adventurers, and but for a few old wounds they’re as dangerous as they were in their youth.”

Reynold pointed out a group of men and women marching smartly down the street. They certainly did look older than normal, but Ryoka saw the confident way each one walked. She saw them pass by as the carriage moved onwards.

That was another thing. The city had a street and sidewalk. There were no wagons mixing with pedestrians here—there was a separate route for vehicles such that they could keep moving despite the flow of foot-traffic. Ryoka saw a [Guardswoman] directing traffic and wondered if there were street lights too. That would be too surreal.

“I smell goat meat! And cow meat! And rat meat! And spices! Thyme and rosemary and paprika and qerix and bablyous!”

Ivolethe shouted and leapt from Ryoka’s head. She skimmed to an open stall and laughed as the vendor swore and tried to protect his wares on display. Ryoka passed by one of the open markets in the city and saw countless stalls like the ones in Liscor, all open, all filled with [Merchants] and [Traders] doing business with people there.

“How many people live here?”

She shouted at Reynold as he drove the carriage up a street. He had to raise his voice to reply.

“I couldn’t say how many, Miss! This city is so vast—and there are countless towns and villages only a stone’s throw away!”

It couldn’t be a million. Ryoka was sure...but well, why not? She knew cities like Paris and London had boasted over a hundred thousand people in the middle ages. This city was surely as large—no, larger than they were. If you counted the suburbs and outskirts, why not?

“Unbelievable.”

She whispered the words as the carriage rode on. Now Reynold was taking her into the heart of the business district, as far as she could tell. Shops passed by on the right and left and she heard people calling out to her as she passed.

“Milady, a moment, please! Would you be interested in the latest wares from Baleros? A shipment has come in from T’vault, please see!”

“I have the latest treats from Terandria, right here! Try our fabulous new treat, a frozen delight! You won’t be able to say no to another lick!”

The man was talking about ice cream! Ryoka saw it being served in a shop—the man there was putting it on little gold platters for people to sample. She looked over to the other side of the street and saw a huge plaza pass by. The people shouting there seemed to be aiming for warriors, judging by the calls.

“Want a Shield Spider? Invaluable protection—don’t fear it turning on you! An expert [Beast Master] has trained it to fight and obey your every command!”

“Our group is seeking work! A [Jarl] and [Raiders] are willing to fight at your command!”

“I have a pot of Everburning Flame here! Make me an offer, quickly!”

“The Windfrozen Riders are available for commission—”

“Hire the Celestial Trackers and we will find your quarry or your coin back ___”

The voices were swept away as Ryoka passed by. She turned her head to look and spoke to Ivolethe.

“I might have to get an Everburning Flame while I’m here. It could be seriously useful, especially if I can build a primitive steam engine or something. Hell, I could probably find a [Blacksmith] to make me the parts.”

The Frost Faerie laughed.

“Hah! Yon fool lies. That pot is filled with naught but oil. ‘Tis an alchemist’s trick—it will burn for a week before running out.”

“Damn. How can you tell?”

“‘Twas not magic. And I caught the odor of the burnt oil as we passed. How could you *not* tell?”

Ryoka stared at Ivolethe, impressed.

“I’m going to take you when I go shopping.”

“After you buy me meat! You promised!”

“I need to take care of business first. Reynold, where’s the Runner’s Guild in the city?”

“We’re arriving at the largest branch now, Miss Ryoka.”

Reynold pointed, and Ryoka saw a large building to one side. It was painted like most of the buildings in the city—a light blue color, and she saw there were three sets of doors that were constantly in use as citizens came in to claim a package or have one delivered, and Runners went out to make said deliveries.

“Looks like that’s my stop. Should I wait for you there?”

“I’m afraid I will have to park this carriage at a spot designated for Lady Reinhart’s vehicles. Please do not wait for me. Instead, if you will accept this seal, I will locate you.”

Reynold produced one of Lady Magnolia's iconic seals, half-gem, half-silver. Ryoka eyed the translucent sapphire melted together with shining silver metal into a single disc.

"Expensive. Are you sure I need it?"

"It will allow you unfettered access to many establishments, I think you will find, Miss Ryoka. Of course, Lady Reinhart asks that you not make any claims against her name with her token—lending it to you is an act of great trust."

"And it has a tracking spell, doesn't it? That's how you're going to find me."

"Yes, Miss. This is most convenient in such a large city."

Ryoka sighed, but took the token reluctantly.

"Find me as soon as you can and we'll go visit that enchanter."

"Yes, Miss Ryoka."

"And stop calling me Miss!"

Ryoka shouted as she leapt out of the carriage and Reynold drove off. She sighed as Ivolethe flew down and landed on her shoulder.

"Are ye going to take long in yon building?"

"Not too long if I can get past the receptionists without too much fuss. But they'll have to tally all the deliveries I've got...look, just get inside my pouch and wait, alright?"

"Ach, the things that friendship requires."

Grumbling, Ivolethe flew into Ryoka's pouch. The Runner adjusted her belt, and then strode into the Runner's Guild.

Whatever she had been expecting, Ryoka hadn't quite expected the scope of this Guild. She stared around for a second, blinking, as her eyes took in the main Runner's Guild of Invril.

"Wow. That's a lot of Runners."

There had to be over a hundred people in the building. That was three times as many as Ryoka had ever seen in Celum's guild at any one time, and this was only the main building? She saw Runners coming and going, people of all species. A Gnoll with a package tied to a sling around her chest brushed past her, and Ryoka realized there was a steady stream going in and out the doors.

Quickly, the young woman stepped towards the receptionists. There were quite a few of them, and they were dealing with Runners quickly, changing seals for coin, handing out deliveries, and so on. Ryoka stepped into line and found herself advancing in the queue at startling speed.

There was no waiting long in a Runner's Guild it seemed. Ryoka could already see the brisk [Receptionists] talking with Runners at the front. They seemed older than the normal group of young women, and there were men in the mix as well.

Ryoka fidgeted as she reached for her Runner's Seal and bag of holding carrying all the deliveries from Remendia. She still hated talking to new people, especially when it came to Receptionists. They were so chatty—

"Next! Over here, Miss."

Two receptionists finished with their Runner at the same time. Ryoka walked over to a woman in her mid-thirties. She was a String Person, although interestingly, she had pale skin, rather than Octavia or Revi's dark tone. She held out one hand where all the fingers had stitches where they met the hand.

"Your seal, please."

Ryoka placed her personal Runner's seal on the counter. The [Receptionist] snatched it up and produced a magnifying glass to study it in an instant. She only gave it a brief look before sliding it back towards Ryoka.

"Ryoka Griffin? You're a long way from Celum. Are you transferring, or doing a delivery? We didn't receive word you were heading this way."

Ryoka blinked. This receptionist was far more business-like than Ryoka was accustomed to. She hesitated a bit on her reply.

"I'm not transferring. I—was in Remendia and had the chance to come here. I've got a bunch of deliveries from the guild there."

"Really? May I see them?"

Ryoka produced her bag of holding. The [Receptionist]'s gaze sharpened and she held out a hand.

"Wait. Are any of the packages marked confidential or otherwise uniquely addressed in any way?"

"Not that I was told."

"Very well then. Proceed."

Ryoka carefully took wrapped item after item out of the bag of holding, piling it up on the desk. In the end the receptionist had to call for a bin—she began transferring each package into it with quite deliberate movements.

"Well, that accounts for every package we had coming this way. I suppose we'll get less on the weekly delivery."

The [Receptionist] idly commented as she peered at the bin full of deliveries. Ryoka had to smile a bit; she could see some of the other Runners staring jealously at her. The [Receptionist] nodded as she tallied up each delivery on a receipt and stamped it.

"Not bad. But a Courier could have done it just as quickly, or faster if they were heading here directly. If you're going to make a long-distance trip in the future, please inform the Guild so they can send a message, Miss."

The smug smile on Ryoka's face vanished. The woman at the desk looked only vaguely impressed with Ryoka's feat. She handed the receipt to Ryoka.

“You may exchange that for coin now or at any guild, as I’m sure you know. Now, was there anything else, Miss?”

Caught off-guard, Ryoka thought quickly.

“...There is one thing. Do you happen to know if the Courier Valceif Godfrey is in the city?”

The woman at the desk raised her eyebrows.

“Valceif? His usual circuit is closer to First Landing, but he comes here regularly for deliveries...I haven’t seen him of late, which is unusual, but I will ask about his location. If you return here later, I, or another receptionist at the desk, will know more.”

“Thanks.”

“My pleasure, Miss Griffin. Next!”

Bemused, Ryoka wandered away from the desk, seeing a rather battered-looking Dullahan step forwards. She heard him beginning to complain about being attacked by dogs *again* before she stepped out of the guild.

“I guess a big city means the Runners here are that much better.”

“Bah, ‘tis not as if they can run that fast.”

Ivolethe poked her head out of Ryoka’s belt pouch as the young woman stood in the street. Ryoka shook her head; she thought the Runners in that building might all be at Fals’ level, or better. If that was the case, they were all nearly as fast or faster than she was.

“I’m starting to really feel like a country yokel seeing the city for the first time. Until Reynold finds us, how about we go look around? You can get something to eat, and I’ll...take in the sights, I guess.”

Ivolethe happily agreed, and so Ryoka set off down the streets. At first she was uncomfortable, but she quickly got used to the flow of the city.

This place reminded her a lot of New York. There wasn't any stopping and chatting here, not with such a press of people. If you didn't walk fast you got dirty looks—or pushed. The sidewalk was crowded, and when the wagons on the street halted to let pedestrians cross you moved fast or you got shouted at.

Ryoka had the insane urge to shout 'I'm walking here!' just for the hell of it. But that would probably get something hurled at her head by one of the drivers. They certainly traded insults with the foot traffic in a refreshingly familiar way. Although, Ryoka had to admit, she had never seen a pedestrian throw a ball of magic at a driver who shouted obscenities at him.

But aside from the city press, the city of Invril was still a city. And Ryoka had grown up in the urban sprawl. There were places to get food on the sidewalk, and in no time she was eating her own hot skewer and quickly sliding off hot chunks of meat to cram into her belt pouch from another.

Her pouch was going to get greasy and disgusting, but Ivolethe seemed only concerned about the food. Ryoka could feel her rustling around and making happy noises as she ate. And a happy Frost Faerie was one that wasn't freezing your stomach and giving you horrible bowel movements.

"Where to next, I wonder?"

Ryoka stopped in a busy plaza, looking around for signs, perhaps to the market, or maybe to a specialized store specializing in magical artifacts. She had coin after all—a lot of it. It might not be enough for a powerful magical artifact, but it was time to buy a ring or—or enchanted clothing perhaps. What about a wand—

"Watch where you're going, Troll!"

An outraged shout made Ryoka's head turn. She saw a group of armored men and one woman—adventurers?—standing in front of...

Ryoka had to rub her eyes. It was a Troll. Or—no, not a Troll maybe, but a half-Troll?

There was no other word for it. Ryoka hadn't seen a Troll before, but she imagined they'd be a bit bigger, a bit rounder and more...monster-like. But

while this...person wasn't a full Troll, they definitely had some Troll blood in them.

It was hard to describe. Ryoka's first impression was that someone had taken this poor young woman—a young woman with far bigger bones than even Garia—and painted her a greyish color. But that alone wouldn't account for her tough, almost pebble-like skin and towering height. She was over seven feet tall and she looked like a goliath. Not like a tall and lanky basketball player, no, Ryoka thought she looked more like a walking tank. Broad-shouldered didn't even begin to cover it, and her arms were *thick*.

She was wearing rough, simple clothing that looked hand-stitched. The half-Troll was trying to step away from the angry adventurer she'd apparently run into. He wasn't letting her go. He was angry, and, Ryoka thought, overly hostile towards her.

“Of course. Racism at its finest.”

“What is?”

Ivolethe poked her head out of Ryoka's pouch, cheeks bulging. The second she saw the scene she went still. Ryoka shook her head as the adventurer began insulting the half-Troll girl.

He looked like he wanted a fight. Briefly, Ryoka considered stepping in. She had no patience for bullies. And she had a pepper potion and the other items Octavia had given her ready to be used. Except that this adventurer had a group of his friends backing him up. Ryoka eyed them and shook her head.

“Not my business.”

That was what Ryoka decided in the end. She could imagine what would happen if she picked a fight with real adventurers. She'd not only lose, but probably get hurt and maybe get thrown in jail. It wasn't worth it.

“Don’t go! Stay! I want to watch!”

Ivolethe shouted as Ryoka turned to leave. The young woman frowned down into the pouch.

“Why? Do you want to help? I won’t stop you, but be careful. If they think that half-Troll girl is doing it, they’ll attack her.”

“What? Not the half-child, ye daft fool! I want to see what *he* does!”

Ivolethe pointed, and Ryoka saw to her surprise that the Troll girl wasn’t in fact alone. She hadn’t even seen the young man standing by her side; she sort of dominated the scene. But he was standing in silence, listening to the adventurer get angrier and angrier.

The adventurer was *trying* to pick a fight, Ryoka could tell. He had a sword and this half-Troll didn’t. He was a piece of crap, and she would have loved to drop-kick him and stomp on him a bit. But she had a feeling he’d kick her ass if she tried.

She didn’t want to stay and watch this unfold. And yet, she watched the adventurer continue to pick on the half-Troll with narrowed eyes, unable to just walk away.

“Enough. Please stop bothering my companion.”

The young man spoke up at last. He seemed to be talking to the entire group, rather than the belligerent adventurer in front.

“She did nothing wrong. If she walked into you while escorting me, I apologize on both our behalf. But you have no reason to attack her like this.”

The other members of the group seemed to accept this, but the man who’d been knocked into seemed to find this apology too weak, or perhaps he just wanted to cause more trouble for the pair. He swaggered up to the young man, glaring.

“Is she your bodyguard? In that case, you should apologize to us directly! Don’t you know who we are?”

The young man turned his head towards the adventurer, and Ryoka blinked as she saw his eyes were closed.

“I don’t know, or particularly care. Please move aside—we are trying to go about our business and you should do the same.”

“What, are you too good to look me in the eye?”

Outraged, the adventurer seized the young man’s arm. Immediately the half-Troll reacted. She reached for the adventurer to push him back. He immediately leapt back and his friends grabbed for their weapons. Protectively, the Troll girl moved in front of the young man.

“Don’t do that! He’s blind!”

A blind guy? Ryoka had seen few people with disabilities in this world. She wondered if that was because of a lack of pollution or other genetic factors—or if such people died out because they couldn’t defend themselves or contribute.

Either way, the young man’s lack of sight didn’t stop him from being a target. The adventurer began mocking both him and the half-Troll girl, much to Ryoka’s distaste.

“A blind man and a half-Troll! Hah! I suppose that’s the only person who’d put up with something like that!”

The gigantic young woman glared at the adventurer.

“Go away. If you bother Laken, I’ll protect him. I’m his—”

She got no further, because the man interrupted her with a sneer.

“Protect him? You couldn’t protect a fly! I’ve seen real combat, not like some half-monster country bumpkin.”

The half-Troll said nothing, but there was an unfriendly look in her eye, and one of her hands clenched into a fist. A *big* fist. Ryoka eyed it and wondered what would happen if she hit the adventurer with it. His buddies looked a bit worried, but the man in front was drunk on bravado.

“Do you know how many Trolls I’ve killed with this sword? I could etch another notch right here, and no one would care.”

The man put a hand on his sword as he stepped forwards. The half-Troll girl flinched, but then to Ryoka’s surprise the young man moved. He took a step forwards and turned his head towards the adventurer. He was clearly angry, and when his mouth opened the word he spoke *echoed* across the square.

“Enough.”

Ryoka felt something *press* at her chest and had to force herself not to react. The adventurer stumbled back as if something physical had hit him. He put his hands on his sword with a snarl and the half-Troll girl raised a threatening fist. Before the conflict could escalate into bloodshed, Ryoka heard a shout and thumping of boots.

“What’s going on here!?”

The Watch had come, and remarkably quickly too. Ryoka wondered if it had to do with the half-Troll being there—and then corrected her thought. Of course it did. She watched as the two sides explained what had happened from their point of view.

Predictably, the adventurer claimed that the half-Troll had nearly knocked him down and he had simply reacted to the provocation. The blind young man and the half-Troll claimed the opposite. The young man—he was named Laken apparently—was explaining things to the Lieutenant, who didn’t seem too inclined to listen to his side of the case.

“She did nothing wrong. Durene was guiding me through the streets when this man decided to take objection to her existing.”

“So you say, sir. But this adventurer and his friends—a Silver-rank team—claim otherwise.”

The young man’s brows drew together as he snapped.

“I may be blind, but I know what I heard. And other people saw what happened too. Why not ask them? Or better yet, use a truth spell?”

“I hardly think that this situation calls for that.”

The man in charge dismissed the idea as if it were silly. He glanced at the adventurer, who looked pretty damn confident for someone who was probably lying, in Ryoka's opinion. The lieutenant glared up at the half-Troll, who was looking chastened as well as upset.

"I'll let it go with a warning—for both of you. Be on your way sir, and you, Miss—"

He hesitated, made a face, and then went on.

"—Cause no problems in my city while you're here. If I hear of any more disturbances, there will be trouble."

The adventurer took that as his cue to go and swaggered off. Ryoka glared at his back, but the young blind man was still irate.

"You have got to be kidding me. Is this really fair, officer? You and I both know that Durene did nothing wrong. Is it because she's a half-Troll that you're blaming her? Or do you simply not care about justice?"

The lieutenant did not like being told off. His cheeks reddened and he put a hand on his sword until he realized the blind man couldn't see the motion.

"I apologize if you've been inconvenienced sir. Now, move along."

"Come on Laken, let's go."

The half-Troll pulled gently at the young man's shoulder. He clenched his fists, and then relaxed his hands. His fury seemed to wash away in an instant and he looked resigned, rather than upset. Laken nodded and patted Durene's hand.

"Very well, I suppose this guardsman is just doing his job. As we say in my homeland, *fahr zur Hölle du Bullenschwein. Ah entschuldigung, SIE Bullenschwein*. Good day, officer."

The blind man spoke the words directly to the lieutenant, and then smiled at him as if what he'd said had been a compliment. It clearly wasn't, but no one knew what he'd said. The lieutenant frowned, but didn't make an issue of it.

But standing across the street, Ryoka Griffin's eyes suddenly went wide. She felt as if her entire body had suddenly been shocked. She knew what had been said. But more importantly, she knew in what language that had been said. That was no foreign tongue from this world. That was *German!*

Ryoka's heart beat rapidly in her chest as she saw the group of guardsmen stride away, leaving the duo behind. That had to be just a coincidence. Or was it? There weren't any people who spoke German in this world, were there? Well, if everyone here spoke English, why not? Another country could have adopted other languages. And yet—Ryoka's gaze fixed on the blind young man standing next to the upset half-Troll.

"Ivolethe. Why is that guy so special?"

The faerie's voice was tiny in Ryoka's ear.

"I see it on him. The mark of command. The old destiny of leaders."

That made no sense to Ryoka. But she was distracted by the Troll-girl. Durene? She was bending and whispering to the young man, although her voice was quite audible to anyone listening. Ryoka glanced around. Not many people were. They were hurrying around and away from her, rather than stopping to listen.

"What did you say, Laken?"

He turned his head towards her and Ryoka saw him smile. She heard him clearly whisper to the half-Troll as she stepped closer.

"I'll tell you later, Durene. Let's just get to that Runner's Guild first, hm? We can see about adventurers later."

Hesitantly, the half-Troll took the young man's hand. She cast around, and then began to set off through the street, easily clearing a path for him to walk by her. Ryoka hesitated.

She could ignore that and go to the enchanter. She couldn't believe she'd find someone else from her world right here, just like that.

And yet—Ryoka glanced down at her belt pouch. Ivolethe had poked her head out, and she was chewing the last bit of meat. And her eyes were fixed on Laken. The Frost Faerie glanced up at Ryoka, and then away.

Coincidence? Or fate? Was she being led, or was this all some huge chance event? Ryoka didn't know. But as the half-Troll and blind young man walked through the crowds, Ryoka slowly walked after them.

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Day 49

My name is Laken Godart. I am blind. Also, I'm trapped in another world where reality seems to conform to the rules of some kind of game.

I could be a victim of some kind of elaborate prank or test, or a social experiment. I could see myself being an easy target for some kind of shady government project—if of course I'm not just crazy.

Right now, I'm not ruling out any options. The reason why I ended up in this world could be anything as simple as an alien abduction gone wrong to genuine magic. I'm leaning on the magic side, myself.

This place is just too...real. Too real, and I want to believe in it. In the short month and a half since I've been here, I gained sight. Of a kind, yes, but sight nevertheless. I found someone I loved, and I found something to fight for.

But I won't forget to think about what I do. I'm no hero with a sword. I'm fairly certain I'd hurt myself just trying to pick one up. I can't be a warrior.

But I can be smart. I can choose what I want to do and pick my battles, if there are any in the future. I have friends. I have a class.

I am an [Emperor], and I have responsibilities. That, more than anything, informs how I act. Even now, I've travelled to this place, this city, for the people under my protection.

"It really is a big city, isn't it, Durene?"

I say that out loud and feel Durene laughing nervously through our connected hands. I can tell she's next to me. I may be blind, but I have my other senses. Here is what I know. I'm holding Durene's hand. Her palm is callused—rough. Almost like a shark's skin? I touched one once at an

aquarium—a small, non-threatening shark or so I was told. Durene’s skin is somewhat like that.

Her hand is warm. On this cold, brisk day, her hand is warm. And I can hear her every step. But I can also hear the voices.

Oh—the voices. I’ve been in huge cities before, heard cars passing by, honking, shouting, but there’s just something about a mass of *people* that seems large to me. Maybe it’s because I know each person has to be out there, each one an individual moving and talking and thinking on their own.

A hundred voices. A thousand, some shouting, others just talking as they pass by me and Durene. More still simply walk, and it’s that movement which really tells me that I’m in a city.

I can smell—dirt and stone. And sweat, musty odors coming off of winter clothing probably. But more strongly through the air, baked food. Hot tangy scents wafting towards me and making me hungry. Someone’s cooking food over to the left, and the wind’s blowing it towards me. Not a meat—something else?

They’re not the only ones. There are more food vendors all about. Smell, hearing—I’m being overwhelmed on both fronts by the sheer input.

However, I am used to it. I know better than to panic, and it’s hardly like I’m incapable of moving about. I let Durene lead me through the city at a good pace. I just wish—

I wish I could see all of this. Sound and smell only get me so far. But from what Durene tells me, this city is like nothing in my past world.

“Lizard people? Really, Durene?”

“They’re called Drakes, I think. I’ve never seen one before. Um, I think they live far to the south of here.”

“Amazing. Drakes. Draco. Are they related to Dragons, by any chance?”

“I don’t know? They um, have scales. And long tails. Some of them have green scales, others have red or blue or—that one’s yellow.”

Durene moves as if to point and stops herself. I nod to myself as we walk on. I'm trying to imagine what these creatures—these people might be like. But I don't think in terms of sight, naturally. I have a rough image in my head, but I would love to talk to one of these Drakes, shake their...hand?

“Do they have hands?”

“Something like that. It uh, it's more like claws. They look sharp.”

Claw hands. I try to fit that in and reconsider shaking hands. But if I could touch one—

And how would I do that? I'm assuming these other species have the same taboos and social norms—at least broadly—that Humans do. Durene didn't think it was too strange for a city to have Drakes in it, for all she's never seen one.

Maybe if I got to know one. Naturally I can't just stop someone on the street—well, I could, but I have more pressing matters.

I am in this city for a reason. I speak to Durene, feeling her guiding me left to avoid something or someone.

“Would you say we're close to that plaza you saw now?”

“I think so!”

She sounds excited and worried by turns. Excited, and overwhelmed by her first glimpse of a city, as I suppose anyone would be. I have to remember Durene's never even left her village. This must be overwhelming for her. I have to keep the cool head.

And yet, I can't help but feel like Durene's the one who'll be most useful in a pinch. She proved that when she stood up to those adventurers. All I could do was raise my voice and be useless.

Those adventurers...I sigh as I walk with Durene towards the plaza.

Bastards. Ditto for that lieutenant. But the insight into this city was helpful. There's corruption here, or at least, casual racism against one type of species. Ironical, that. I guess in a city with countless races joining hands—or claws—there has to be some group that gets pushed out.

I have to understand the world around me to interact with it. That's why Durene and I have been walking through the city this last hour, taking it in, finding the measure of it. Better that than rush off and make mistakes. And it was a very pleasant walk too—Durene described so many odd sights for me. And yet, I guess you step in dog shit at least once on the best of strolls.

“Ah, I can hear the adventurers shouting now.”

Yes, in my ears I can now pick out a different set of shouts, this one growing louder as Durene and I walk forwards. Adventurers.

“...the Storm Raiders will sell our axes to anyone in need of a strong arm! Make us an offer!”

“—the best, the mightiest! Our shields will block spell and fang alike! The Ironshield Vanguard!”

“We're a group of [Soldiers] who fought in the Yelten-Grimmor conflict! We've over fifty kills between us! You want protection, turn to us!”

Ah, adventurers. Durene leads me forwards, and I can just tell she's stopping to stare around.

“Do you see Gamel around?”

“No.”

Durene sounds worried, although she shouldn't be. I can feel her shift—is she standing on her tiptoes? I imagine she would be able to see practically everyone in the plaza. Even these ‘Gnolls’ don't sound as tall as she is.

“I don't see him, Laken. Should I call out, do you think? Or—”

I squeeze her hand gently, reassuring her.

“Don't worry, Durene. It was just a thought. I imagine he's off in some other square. We did say we'd meet at midday. Correct me if I'm wrong, but we've a little bit of time before then.”

“Yeah. You did say—okay.”

“Let's take a seat—if one's available. I could use a few seconds to rest, and I'd like to listen to what all these people are shouting. You can describe

them for me.”

“Okay.”

We make it a few more steps into the plaza, and then I feel Durene slow. She bends towards me and whispers something in my ear.

“Laken, I think that girl is still following us!”

I pause for only a microsecond, but then move forwards. Durene is stopped.

“I see. Keep walking, Durene. Don’t look back at her—or if you do, just glance past her, as if you haven’t seen her.”

“Okay, Laken. But what does she want?”

“You’re sure she’s following us and not going somewhere else?”

“I’m sure! We practically walked in a circle, and I keep seeing her!”

“Describe her for me again.”

Durene pauses. I can hear the nervousness in her voice when she speaks again.

“Um. Tall. Taller than you, Laken. A few inches taller? She’s...got black hair, darkish skin—I’ve never seen someone who looks like that. Is she a foreigner? Uh—she’s uh—beautiful.”

“Beautiful?”

It’s an alien word to me. Beautiful is a word I associate with a voice, not with faces or appearance. But Durene’s voice is filled with a longing that tells me all I need to know.

“She’s beautiful. Sort of scary-looking, but beautiful. And—she looks like a Runner.”

“Hm.”

Durene spotted the girl following us a few blocks back. She pointed her out to me—well, described her to me—as one of the oddities of the city. A foreigner, someone not native to this continent.

It's a...hard thing for me to think of. I know there are ethnicities in my world, of course. Nationality, race, gender...that's easy to understand. But skin color? I don't know what the color blue is supposed to look like.

Apparently, the folk of Riverfarm and this continent look predominantly like the people of my home continent, Europe. That is to say, mostly fair-skinned. This girl isn't. She could be black or Asian or Latino—Durene's descriptions don't help me think of her in that way. She's just clearly a foreigner, and one who stands out in this multi-species environment. No—more so because she stands out among her own kind, Humans.

And she's following us. What does that mean? I frown as Durene worries next to me.

“Let's get to a seat, and you can tell me if she stays in the area. If she doesn't—well, we'll know then.”

“Got it.”

Durene's palm is slightly sweaty in my hand. Or is it mine? Because I hate to imagine it, but this could be an issue.

Why would someone follow us? A thousand reasons come to mind. They might be a prejudiced asshole like the adventurers. Or they might be interested in Durene. Or maybe it's something to do with me?

I'm in a gaming world. Is this just a random event? Is this a scripted NPC? I'm sure this isn't that kind of game, but why else would someone follow us? Is she aware of Riverfarm's plight? Is she simply curious about an interspecies couple?

I don't know. But I think. That's what I can do in this world. Think. Think, and try to understand. Who is this young woman? What does she want?

And what should I do about it?

Ryoka Griffin gritted her teeth as she saw the half-Troll's head turn. She slowed, but the tall girl's head found her.

"She can't have spotted me. She can't."

Ryoka muttered under her breath as the girl named Durene seemed to glance at her, and then hurriedly look past. It was the third time she'd done so in as many minutes. It made Ryoka worried.

And annoyed, because Ryoka really didn't want to think she'd been spotted by a Troll. Half-Troll. Whatever. That would be embarrassing, and yet—

"She saw me. Damn, damn, *damn*..."

In writing, it sounded easy. Follow a blind guy being led around by a half-Troll. How hard could that be? It was probably wrong to think, but Ryoka had the impression that the half-Troll girl wasn't exactly the fastest brick on the block. She seemed simple, somewhat timid, and gentle. A giant, in short, easy to follow without being seen while Ryoka listened to what the two were doing.

But the Troll—Durene was her name, wasn't it?—kept looking around. Ryoka felt the half-Troll girl's eyes pause on her again and tried to meld with a group of laughing Drakes. But the problem was that becoming one with the crowd only worked if the crowd was the same species as you were. And for all her varied interests over the years, Ryoka had never tried espionage. To be more accurate, she'd never tried following someone who kept pausing every few minutes to stare about.

In movies or in books, the protagonist following the suspect had the advantage of darkness, or an unaware target, or some convenient plot twist which would help them complete their mission. And at the very least, they could blend with the crowd.

But Ryoka stood out. She *knew* she stood out. She was an Asian girl who didn't look like the other native Humans to this land, and certainly not like the other species. So she'd been spotted with disgusting ease. The blind guy couldn't see her, but his helper could, and she kept staring around—probably to tell him what everything looked like!

That was one side of the problem. The Troll-girl saw Ryoka. She saw Ryoka, but Ryoka saw the man following the pair. That was someone the half-Troll hadn't spotted.

And no wonder—he was completely bland. He had flaxen hair, a nondescript face—his clothes weren't anything to blink twice over. And yet, he was following the blind man known as Laken and the half-Troll Durene as well, Ryoka was sure of it.

He was following them, and Ryoka wanted to know why. She kept eying the man as she walked into the plaza with all the adventurers lined up. They were an odd bunch. It looked as though each one had their space to, well, show off. Teams of adventurers—Silver-rank at best by the looks of them—were doing tricks with swords or just trying to give off a certain amount of swagger as their teammates or hired help extolled their virtues, trying to get them a job.

It was an odd way of doing things, but Ryoka supposed it was needed advertisement if you wanted a lucrative contract. In a place with so many adventurers—Ryoka saw one every block it seemed—people with requests could choose their team, which meant competition had to be fierce.

Now the human and half-Troll seemed to be stopping. They were headed for some unoccupied benches sitting in the shade of some trees in the plaza. Ryoka bit her lip.

She hadn't gotten close enough to hear more than a few snippets of conversation and she'd already been made. Should she try to get close, knowing she was exposed?

It had just been a few words. In German. Just a few words—why couldn't there be some nation based off of Germany, or some culture with Germanic roots? But Ryoka had to know.

So she walked closer. She looked around—where was that man in plain clothes? *He* was a master at being invisible. Ryoka would never have spotted him if she hadn't noticed him following the pair like she was.

There. He was strolling ahead of her, right next to the half-Troll. Ryoka's eyes narrowed. She watched as he approached, and then cursed.

“Son of a—”

It happened in a moment as we were walking towards the bench that Durene had found. I, walking by her side, felt her pause for a second.

“Oh! I’m so sorry!”

“My fault, Miss. Please excuse me.”

An unfamiliar voice. Male. Pleasant. I frown and hear him walk away.

“What was that, Durene?”

“Nothing, Laken. I just bumped into that man.”

“Huh.”

Durene sounds at ease, but my frown remains. Something feels wrong. Bumped into her. Why does that...

Who would bump into someone as big as Durene? From what she’s said, she gets a lot of room even on a busy sidewalk. Who goes around bumping into people ordinarily, anyways? And the way he said it—

“Durene! Check your money pouch!”

I snap as thoughts come together in an instant. I’ve encountered thieves and pickpockets before. I know the scam. I hear Durene gasp and then her anguished shout.

“It’s gone! He took it!”

“Go after him!”

“But—”

“Go, Durene!”

I shout, letting go of her hands. That's not just her money that was taken—Durene had the entire pouch of coin and gems I found by her cottage! If that thief runs off with it—

To her credit, I hear Durene hesitate only for a second. Then I feel her turn and run away from me. Then her voice.

“Stop! Thief!”

It's a shout that drowns out all sound for a second. Durene has an impressive pair of lungs, and I can practically hear the thief's heart stop as she runs towards him.

I stand in the plaza, not moving, fishing in the small rucksack I'm carrying for something. I pull out my foldable cane and extend it fully.

I haven't had to use it in a while. I decided not to use it when Durene was walking me around—I trust her completely and it might have gotten in the way of all the pedestrians about. But it's a useful tool now.

A quick check—I tap carefully in a circle around me and find the bench we were about to sit at. I move over to it and sit down.

It's not as if I'm not panicking right now. A thief, taking all the money Durene and I have—the money meant for Riverfarm? That's a disaster. But what can I do in this situation? Panic?

Durene's chasing after the thief. Either she gets him or she doesn't. I can only make things worse by shouting and running about. So I sit and try to think.

If she fails to get him—we have to talk to the Watch. But can we get our money back? It's not like I had a credit card—that gold and those gems are probably as good as gone the instant they're lost. And would the local law enforcement help us? The way they treated Durene—

I wrench my mind off of that train of thought. Consider the worst when it's over. The real question is—why target Durene? Who steals from a half-Troll? I haven't ever really laid eyes on Durene, it's true, but a girl who towers over the biggest Human and who can probably bench press a horse is *not* someone I'd expect pickpockets to normally go after.

Unless that's normal in this world. No—it can't be. Did that cutpurse realize how much money she was carrying? Or—

“Damn. A Skill. It must be that.”

Why didn't I think of it? It's a reasonable explanation. If you assume there's a class for everything, and that's what Durene seems to believe, then there's definitely a [Thief] class. And what better Skill than one that allows someone to pick out an easy mark? Or a rich one?

I clench one fist as I hear Durene's shouting and the commotion growing more distant. Pray. Hope. And think about what to do if she doesn't catch him—

“Excuse me. Is your name Laken?”

I start. A voice—a female voice comes from above and to my left. I turn my head.

“Hello. Pardon me, but have we met?”

“Not before. But tell me—*woher kommst du?*”

The pronunciation is terrible, and the words are stilted, spoken without fluency. But I stiffen nonetheless, because I know German when I hear it.

And I know that no one on this continent speaks German, as far as Durene or Gamel know.

So why is someone speaking it to me right now?

In the time it takes for me to clear my throat and respond, my thought process is simple. Who's talking to me? It has to be the girl Durene spotted. Why?

Well, either she thinks I'm from her country or, more probably—

“*Aus San Francisco. Und Sie?*”

A sharp, indrawn breath is my only answer. But it's the only one I need.

“*Dieu merci.* I am not alone.”

Can you feel shock, amazement, relief, and confusion all at once? I'm sure there is one, even if it's not an English word. There are words in other languages for feelings that are never fully translatable into English.

The Norwegian word *forelsket* for instance—I feel that towards Durene every time I touch her. I suppose in lieu of a word now, I think I'll go with 'relief' as incomplete as it may be.

"I am not alone."

I feel tears spring into my eyes, gathering behind my eyelids. As strange as it may sound, I really did think I was alone up until this moment. Alone, in a new world.

But there's someone else. I stand up, and hear someone take a step back. There's noise all around us—has Durene caught the thief? I can't focus on that. Suddenly, I'm in a small bubble with this girl.

"You're—from home, aren't you? Earth?"

"Yes."

"My god. Excuse me, but who are you? I'm blind—are you the young woman who was following us around earlier?"

A pause. I listen, heart beating, before the young woman replies in a low voice.

"I am. I'm—a friend. My name is Ryoka Griffin. Tell me, when did you get here? Do you know why you came to this world? Who have you talked to—who's that girl who was with you?"

The questions are like a storm, tersely delivered. I hear in them echoes of all the things I want to know.

"My name is Laken. Laken Godart. I came here a little over a month ago. I don't know how or why—the girl's name is Durene. She's my guide, my friend. She found me when I first came to this world."

"I see."

"Where is she, do you know? She ran off—"

“After the thief. I think she got him.”

“She did?”

I’m astonished, but there’s a flicker of amusement in Ryoka’s tone.

“Yeah. She picked him up and threw him on the ground. I think she broke some of his bones.”

“*Durene?*”

I can’t imagine it. Well, I can, but I can’t imagine *her* doing that. But this strange young woman seems focused. I hear her moving closer and resist the urge to reach out to try and touch her.

“Look, I don’t have a lot of time before your friend gets back.”

“Why would that—”

“Do you have a cellphone? Flashlight? Anything—anything from our world?”

The question catches me by surprise, but then I fumble at my pocket, and then remember and grab for my rucksack.

“I do. I have an iPhone—it’s practically out of battery, and there’s no signal obviously, but—”

“You can recharge it.”

“*Really?*”

“If a mage casts a [Repair] spell it’ll go back to full charge. Okay, listen. Did you get a call—no, you wouldn’t have if you were only here for two months...huh...”

I can tell she’s thinking hard about something. Myself, I’m just astonished. Mage? [Repair] spell? You mean I can charge up my phone in this world with magic? What possibilities might that unlock?

Then I hear Ryoka’s voice in my ears and jerk away. She’s so *close*! And she’s whispering, very urgently.

“Listen up. You’re not entirely safe with that iPhone. You might be tracked with it—there are people in this world who know we come from another one. If you get a call on your phone, don’t answer it. There are more of us in this world, but—”

“Hold on, hold on! More of us?”

I can’t process everything that she’s saying. Ryoka shakes her head—I know because her hair hits my face slightly as her head moves.

“I can’t give you the full details, not yet. Look, we need to talk. Why don’t we meet up later? I have something to do now, but I can meet you here in—an hour. Can you wait until then?”

My head is spinning, but I nod.

“I can. I’ll be here.”

“Good.”

She’s gone before I can give voice to the questions in my mind. At least, I think she’s gone. I tap around cautiously with my cane—she could be just out of range and I’d never know.

What was that? I sit back down on the bench; my knees are shaking. Before I can collect my thoughts, I hear a voice speaking to me again.

“Sir? Are you the friend of Miss Durene?”

For a second I think Ryoka has come back. But it’s not her—the speaker is different. There’s a bit of a growl to her tone that makes me think of a dog. And worry. Dogs scare me. I’ve been bitten three times while walking—I can’t tell where they are until I run into one, and if the owner’s not got a leash or isn’t attentive, some of them take objection to my presence.

But this is no dog. It must be a Gnoll! I stand up, turning my head in the direction of the speaker.

“Can I help you...Miss?”

“Yes, sir. My name is Raisha, and I am a [Guardswoman] on duty. I am told you are blind. Well, I would like you to know that I have recovered your lost belongings.”

“I got it, Laken!”

Durene calls out and I realize she’s standing with Raisha. I smile.

“You caught the thief?”

“Yes, your friend broke his arm and several ribs.”

An amused tone enters Raisha’s growling voice. She touches something which makes a metallic noise.

“He has been arrested and will be charged. However, I would like to confirm that this bag—”

She hefts something metallic with a strained grunt.

“—is yours. Is this so?”

I’m confused and say so.

“It is—but Durene, you were carrying it.”

“Yes, but...well, it *is* yours, Laken!”

That’s true, but I have to shake my head over Durene’s semantics. Raisha, the Gnoll [Guardswoman], doesn’t seem to care who owns what.

“I don’t need to know who was carrying what. The issue is simple, sir. I just need to prove that you are the owner.”

“How?”

Now I’m worried. It’s not as if I could prove anything. Raisha opens something with a *snap* and rummages around in some sort of purse.

“I have here a gem enchanted with a spell of [Detect Truth], sir. It will tell if you are indeed the owner of the stolen goods. Will you comply with this test?”

“Truth spell? Well—certainly. What do I need to do?”

“Place your hand out, palm up. Good—”

I feel something small and hard drop into my palm. It’s cold and I jump a bit. Raisha’s voice is calm.

“I will ask you one question. Please answer yes or no. Is this stolen pouch of coin yours?”

“Yes.”

I can’t help but feel worried. It’s *technically* mine by the uncertain rules of finders keepers, and it was on Durene’s property, which is to say, mine. And it was a byproduct of a Skill, but I can’t help but tense a bit. I wait for any reaction, but the cue must have been visual.

“You’re speaking the truth. Thank you sir, I just had to check. Your friend has your belongings now. Thank you for cooperating. I regret that you were the victim of this crime, and hope you will have a pleasant day.”

“Oh—thank you.”

Raisha leaves. Durene steps over, and bends down to talk to me.

“Laken, it was amazing! I ran after that thief—I thought I’d lose him, but I just kept on shouting and someone tripped him up for me! Then I grabbed him and threw him down—I didn’t *mean* to break anything, but I was just so worried he’d run away! And then Raisha ran over and said that she’d never seen a dumber [Thief]—trying to steal from me I mean, and—”

It’s too much for me. I sit back down hard. Unfortunately, I miss the bench and land hard on the paving stones in the plaza. That hurts.

“*Laken!* Are you alright?”

“I’m fine, Durene. It’s just...something happened when you were gone.”

“What?”

I have to laugh as Durene helps me sit down on the bench. How can I tell her? It’s actually easy to say, really. I met someone from my world. Six words. The rest is just speculation.

“I can’t believe it.”

I say it again as we sit together. Durene is silent, thinking. I told her what happened. I wouldn’t keep a secret like this from Durene. I don’t think I’d keep anything from her.

“Do you know why she found you? I mean, how?”

“I have no idea. I just know that she must have been watching us—she was talking to me in German, so she must have heard my comment to that guardsman earlier. It might have been coincidence or—she knows about me some other way.”

“How?”

“I don’t know. Magic? Or maybe—she mentioned my iPhone might be used to track me somehow. I wonder, can they use the GPS...? I’d imagine it has to be on, but...”

I trail off. After a moment Durene speaks.

“What are you going to do, Laken?”

“Do? Wait for her. But do it intelligently. Before she gets back, I want to just sit—sit and think, Durene.”

“Okay.”

She’s a good listener. I have to smile, and when I reach out, she takes my hand. For a few seconds we sit together, sitting *together*, not just on the same bench. I feel myself calm down and when I have my thoughts in order, tell her what they are.

“We learned a lot, and not just that there are other people like me, Durene.”

“What do you mean?”

“I think we had better find a bank—or some kind of moneylender. That thief didn’t go after you by chance. Also, I had no idea there were truth spells in this world until very recently.”

“You didn’t? I mean—of course you—but you have things like that in your world, right?”

“Nothing like that. Oh, we have something called a lie detector test—it can’t be trusted. There’s no certainty, no knowing if someone’s telling the truth like this.”

“Wow.”

“Yeah. Truth spells, huh? If we had that where I come from, politics might be a lot different.”

I shake my head, thinking about what that might mean. Fact: that guardswoman had a truth stone. Even if that’s only because this is a prosperous city, it means that a truth spell isn’t out of the reach of an affluent member of society. So...

“Things just got a lot more complicated, Durene. I think we’d better wait for Gamel and Ryoka Griffin right here, but in the meantime, here’s what I think we should do.”

“Yes?”

Durene’s voice is quivering with...anticipation. She doesn’t seem scared, only focused and ready to act. It seems like when the chips are down, she’s not afraid to be bold.

I admire that—I’m completely scared spitless by recent developments. But—I smile.

“I smell good food. If I hold down the bench here, you can get us lunch. And something for Gamel too.”

“Really? Food?”

Durene is incredulous. I shake my head.

“There’s no use thinking on an empty stomach. And believe me, we’ve got a lot of thinking to do.”

“*Damn, damn, damn, damn, damn—*”

Ryoka stalked down the street, cursing under her breath. She was upset. Not upset at what had just transpired, but she was—tense.

“Why are ye cursing? You spoke with the blind man while his protector was away, did ye not?”

Ivolethe piped up from her position in Ryoka’s belt pouch. The young woman paused and took a breath.

“I did. It’s just—hell, Ivolethe. Was that the right thing to do?”

The faerie’s answer was an eloquent shrug. She’d found a bug from somewhere and was holding the squirming insect as she pulled a leg off of it. Ryoka had to pause, with people passing by her from every side and giving her dirty looks, to admire that.

“You’re a monster.”

“Hah! You eat cows and sheep and birds! What’s a small insect to all that?”

“I don’t eat them live.”

Ryoka paled a bit as Ivolethe tore the twitching leg off and bit at the insect’s abdomen. She closed the belt pouch for a few seconds and collected her thoughts.

“He’s from another world. Fuck. Okay. He’s from another world. What do I do now?”

The Frost Faerie poked her head out and shrugged. She was licking something off her face—Ryoka looked away.

“Who says you have aught to do? ‘Tis not your business whether he lives or dies. Why not do what ye need to? You have duties. Your enchanted items, learning to run like the wind—”

“I know. I know, but—I can’t just ignore him. He could know something important. He could...I can’t just ignore someone else. It’s one thing to know about the kids Magnolia has, but she has no idea about Laken. I want to keep it that way, warn him.”

“A smart idea. Perhaps.”

Ryoka glanced down sharply at Ivolethe, but the Frost Faerie’s comment could have been just an offhand insult. After a moment, Ryoka nodded and resumed striding down the street.

“Let’s just find Reynold. I thought he’d catch up by now, but he might have had trouble parking that carriage. That was lucky.”

“Hm. Perhaps.”

Ryoka wondered if Ivolethe *liked* giving her ulcers, or if the faerie didn’t know what effect her words had on Ryoka’s paranoia. No. She had to know. Ryoka shook her head as she made her way out of the plaza—she saw as she went out, some farmer’s kid pleading with a group of adventurers.

“Sirs, please! My village is—it needs protection! We don’t have much money to spare, but—”

He got no further because the adventuring team—a rough-looking group of warriors led by a huge man armored like a Viking—turned away from him in disgust. The young man despondently hurried over to the next group as Ryoka shook her head.

Poor people, without money or friends. It was the same in every world; those who had neither got stepped on. She walked swiftly away, hearing him begin pleading with another group and hoping that he found someone who would listen.

After five minutes Ryoka did find Reynold, or rather, he found her. She was nearly back at the Runner's Guild when she saw him walking towards her down the street. He...stood out.

A [Butler] walking down the streets of New York City would stand out, and Invisil was close in nature to fit that analogy. Heads were turning as the trim and elegant Reynold proceeded down the street. He stopped and nodded politely to Ryoka; a grunt was his response

"Took you long enough."

"My apologies, Miss Ryoka. I was unavoidably detained. May I escort you to your desired meeting with the [Enchanter] in charge of your artifacts now?"

"Lead on."

The two turned and Reynold led Ryoka away from the business district, into an upscale area clearly occupied by the wealthiest individuals. It was still a place for work to be done, but these were clearly homes that doubled as working places. Ryoka was relieved that Reynold set a good pace; for a man who dressed like a Victorian-era servant, he certainly could move quick.

"I never asked, but you know how to fight, don't you? Magnolia wouldn't hire a normal [Butler]. Not her."

"I do indeed have a few levels in, ah, auxiliary classes which inform my main class, miss."

"Really? Were you a former adventurer?"

Reynold turned his head slightly. Ryoka met his gaze.

"No, Miss. Not an adventurer."

There was a tone in his voice that shut down the conversation. Ryoka had used it countless times before. She debated pressing him further, but she couldn't quite make herself be that rude. She sort of liked Reynold.

"Here we are, Miss."

Reynold led Ryoka to a rather plain door. Ryoka blinked at the grey granite door and lion knocker. Reynold stepped up and rapped the knocker twice smartly. The Runner stared up at the building that looked like it had been carved completely out of a single block of granite and snorted. It stood out from the elegant facades and buildings covered in paint and architectural daring.

“I can’t say I admire this [Enchanter]’s sense of aesthetics. This building is an eyesore.”

“It is shaped to contain magic. Stone is a necessity to avoid leakage; paint wears away in no time. My dwelling is plain because I have shaped it for function, not visibility.”

A calm voice came from the doorknocker. Ryoka jumped as she saw the lion’s stone eyes had shifted to stare at her.

“You are Ryoka Griffin. And you are Lady Reinhart’s representative? Enter.”

The door swung out, revealing a far more impressively-decorated interior. Ryoka blinked at the rosewood floor and well-lit entryway. Then she stepped into the [Enchanter]’s house.

The door closed behind Reynold as the two walked down the corridor. The inside of the [Enchanter]’s house was no featureless stone building. The flooring, walls, and hanging glass globes of mage light were all extremely costly. But Ryoka’s eye was drawn more to the decorations on the wall.

Wands, swords, a shield, a helmet on a stand or a single metal gauntlet adorned the walls of the [Enchanter]’s home. Ryoka realized in a few seconds that these were ornaments as well as the merchandise; she still had to blink as she entered a living room where a massive greatsword hung over the fireplace.

“I am in my work room. Please, take the door across from you and proceed left down the hallway.”

A voice echoed throughout the house. Ryoka did as instructed, and found herself in a large room filled with oddities.

The first thing she noticed was a circle drawn in the center of the room, a complex diagram of countless lines that formed...well, a circle was the rough shape, but the pieces that made it up were countless symbols joined together—

They glowed white-blue as Ryoka stared at them and she looked away, blinking as her head began to ache. When she could see again she saw a man standing along one wall of the room, holding a sword in his hands.

It was one of the swords that the Horns of Hammerad had recovered. As Ryoka watched, he lowered it into a tub, a wooden basin holding...what?

Dust? No—iron dust, small fillings as fine as powder. The man muttered a word and Ryoka saw the sword's blade flash in the basin. When the man pulled the sword out, the iron dust had clung to the blade of the sword in a strange pattern. It was clearly a magical symbol, and it changed as Ryoka watched.

“Clever.”

The [Enchanter] turned and the dust fell back into the basin. He nodded at her. Ryoka was surprised to see this man was barely thirty years old. He didn't seem old at all, but he had a pale cast to his skin that spoke of staying out of the light far too often, and he was missing the ring finger on his left hand.

He was clean shaven, had pale orange hair, a nervous tic where he would tap an object twice with his left finger, and a businesslike attitude. He nodded to Ryoka.

“Yes, the iron dust magnetizes when exposed to the enchantments under the right circumstances. Not with all enchantments, but it is a preferable alternative to other sundry materials.”

He gestured, and Ryoka saw there were other basins in the room containing similar materials. This man also had an anvil and hammer leaning against the wall. No fire though—he'd probably conjure that, wouldn't he?

“You have quite the setup.”

Ryoka nodded at the anvil. The man didn't turn his head.

“I do. Now, you have come to have the qualities of your magical items explained, yes? I assume the nature of these artifacts may be shared with the servant accompanying you? And the...thing in your belt pouch?”

“How did you—”

The [Enchanter] tapped the back of his right hand with his left hand’s finger.

“All transactions and words uttered within my abode are private. They will not be shared; rest assured, my wards will keep out even the most powerful of mages from listening in without my knowledge.”

Ryoka glanced behind her at Reynold, who had taken a position by the door. The [Butler] nodded politely at the mage.

“Mister Hedault’s services are recognized as the best in the city. He is extremely competent, and does not reveal any information passed to him in confidence.”

Hedault made no reaction to Reynold’s words. He stared at Ryoka with a fixed, off-putting, focused stare.

“I put a question to you. Will you share the information with the [Butler] and creature you are carrying?”

“Yes.”

Ryoka muffled the outraged shout from her belt pouch. She stared around and found the items she’d given Reynold to have appraised. A silvery circular buckler with a hairline scratch, a sword whose hilt was burnt but had little else wrong with it, the blade of a sword—the metal deformed in two places, and a dagger. The dagger was curved and sharp; Ryoka thought the tip was reddish, but aside from that the weapons appeared like normal, functional killing instruments. But not magical artifacts.

Then again, what did she know? Ryoka spotted two other small objects—a pack and a small bag that looked like it held only a few objects inside. An adventurer’s pack and bag of holding.

“Did you analyze everything?”

“Yes. I shall list the properties of each artifact first, and then inform you as to the nature of any damages that may have occurred and the probable cost of repair. Please, do not interrupt.”

“Hold on. Do you mean—”

Hedault turned and stared flatly at Ryoka. The girl rolled her eyes and closed her mouth.

“Very well. To begin with, this sword. It is worthless.”

The man walked over to the sword blade without the hilt and lifted it to show Ryoka. He pointed at the melted bits of metal.

“See how the blade has been melted from the heat? The enchantments are broken. Unable to be reconstructed. There is no merit to using the blade; the magic is defunct.”

“Can anything be salvaged? Could you study the enchantment—tell us what it does?”

Another flat look. Hedault tapped the blade twice with his finger and replied testily.

“If there were any use for it I would have stated. I asked you to remain silent.”

“Yeah, but I like asking questions.”

This time Ryoka saw the man’s eye twitch. Hedault placed the sword blade back on the table without another word.

“Next, this dagger. It is unharmed from the fire damage. Curiously, it was not affected despite the enchantment not being warded against magical damages. I can only surmise luck played a role in this—”

“Do you want to know where these weapons came from?”

Ryoka couldn’t resist breaking in, just to annoy Hedault, really. He looked at her and she saw Reynold covering his face out of the corner of her eye.

“I do not have to ask. I know. These came from Albez.”

“You could tell?”

“The enchantment style matches the other artifacts recovered from that location. Moreover, rumor points to the Horns of Hammerad having found magical items in that ruin recently. It matters not; the enchantment speaks for itself. Do not ask another question or I will silence you with a spell.”

Ryoka shut her mouth and raised her hands. Hedault sighed and tapped the blade of the dagger twice.

“Note the tip. The blade is common steel, but it is warded against physical harm and heat. When a word is spoken, the tip will ignite. However, the heat will be contained. Thus, when using it like so—*Terith*.”

He spoke a word and Ryoka saw the tip of the blade began to glow red. But not a bright hot-red; rather, the color seemed almost illusory, a red overlay over the plain steel blade. Hedault turned with the blade extended away from him.

“Observe.”

There was a piece of firewood on the table. Hedault picked it up and touched the tip of the dagger to it.

The entire block of wood burst into flame. Ryoka recoiled and stared at Hedault’s hand, but the man had hurled the firewood away. It hung in the air, burning fiercely as he lowered the dagger.

“*Termas*.”

The color on the blade returned to normal. Hedault placed the dagger back on the table as the firewood burned in the air behind him. He waved his hand and the blaze ceased, leaving the wood charred but intact.

“As you can see, the flame enchantment is not for heat per se, but to spread fire. An important distinction. The contact radius of the flame is around... the volume of a tree, I should say. Or an Ogre. With it, it would be possible to immolate several targets at once, but the flames will be non-magical. Alternatively, it is possible to set fire to something like the surface of a lake, although the magical aspect of the flame will last for seconds—it will quickly extinguish if the material is not readily combustible.”

“Jeeze.”

Ryoka breathed the words, her heart still pounding.

“*That* was magic.”

Hedault stared at Ryoka. She bit her lip, remembering his injunction. But he smiled, turning up his pale lips for the first time since she’d seen him.

“It was. A competent spell. Too often the blades I see with heat enchantments are simply *hot*. But this? A useful tool for a mage to distract the enemy, especially if used with telekinetic spells to strike at range, as the old [Battlemages] often did. Now—”

He turned to the sword. Hedault sighed as he picked it up.

“An intact blade of weight. The enchantment is finer than most, but it is unremarkable.”

He turned and raised a finger to forestall Ryoka’s question.

“This is a common enchantment favored by warriors. It amplifies the weight of the blade when struck with. So—”

He raised the blade and tapped it on the wooden table, using the flat of the blade rather than the edge. The table broke with a *crash* that made Reynold and Ryoka jump. Hedault blinked at all the weapons lying on the ground and *tsked*.

“Well, this blade is quite powerful I suppose, but otherwise uninteresting. A valuable weapon for a warrior, I suppose. With this grade of enchantment... you could very well fight a creature such as a Wyvern and cleanly slice through its hide with the right swing. Next.”

He put the blade on another table as he levitated the buckler out of the broken wood. Hedault seemed to grow morose as he touched it, showing Ryoka a hairline fracture on the center.

“A shame. This shield is damaged and requires repair. However, the enchantment is largely intact—it will emit a field around the buckler of around three feet in every direction. It is hard to describe to a non-mage—consider it a moving barrier extending the natural shield, with it as the

focus. Such a barrier is practically impervious to most weapons, although a strong blow may destabilize it. And of course, the true benefit of such a shield is that it is practically weightless—”

“A force shield.”

Ryoka breathed the words. Hedault cocked his head and nodded.

“Crude, but accurate. This buckler is highly useful, not to mention original. But as I said, it must be repaired first. I will inform you as to the cost later. Now, these conclude the weapons recovered. But this—”

He turned to the adventurer’s pack and flicked his fingers at it. It rose and spilled out its contents into the air.

“Those who recovered this pack were wise not to disturb it. However, there was no trap spell on the bag, merely one to prevent it being opened by the wrong user and reinforce the materials. I have bypassed that; here are the contents.”

He showed Ryoka a sheaf of very cracked and faded papers, a broken inkpot whose contents had spilled over some other objects including flint and steel, waterskin, small brush—a toothbrush?—sealed jars, a small gold ring...

“Most objects were mundane and of little worth. There was also a quantity of rotten food which I disposed of.”

Hedault shuddered and tapped his hand against the bag before levitating something up to show Ryoka.

“—This is what is valuable. These four potions are, in order, a healing potion, a potion to provide sustenance, and two potions which prevent the user from needing to breathe.”

He held out a hand, forestalling Ryoka, but this time the girl didn’t speak. Hedault eyed the smiling Ryoka and explained.

“The potion to provide sustenance is a rare acquisition that [Alchemists] may pay well for. It is not a common discovery in adventurer’s packs however, as they generally fail to stopper said potions correctly...this one is untouched. Drinking a small bit will forestall hunger for a day. Drinking the

entire potion at once will provide sustenance for up to a month depending on the level of exertion, and the user will find it difficult to imbibe any other foods in the meantime although it is possible...”

“And the breathing potions?”

“Exactly what they sound like. Generally such potions have the efficacy to provide their users to hold their breath for...two hours. Note that the creation of such potions differ...you may wish to consult an alchemist, but a majority of the potions were made to be held in the mouth rather than swallowed. Swallowing such a potion may result in extreme indigestion. Explosive effects tend to ensue.”

Explosive? Ryoka could just imagine what that meant, and wished she couldn't. Hedault placed the potions back in the pack dismissively.

“Next. The last items of value are this bag of pebbles and ball.”

He pulled out a bag filled with tiny circular, flat stones and a ball which was made out of leather. Someone had stitched an angry face onto the leather in red thread. Ryoka was tickled by it. Hedault gestured to the pebbles.

“Each one is enchanted to shed [Light] for twenty four hours before fading until exposed to sunlight for an equal amount of time. A useful tool I suppose. But this ball...is quite extraordinary.”

He had that look which told Ryoka it was more interesting than the rest. She stared at it. Hedault pointed to the face stitched in the leather.

“Note the symbol. This one is meant to provoke an opponent. If it is touched here, and then thrown—”

The instant his finger touched the ball, Ryoka saw the stitching contort. The face contorted, and then began to *scream*.

Instantly Ryoka clapped her ears to her head. Reynold did the same, but Hedault just tossed the ball. It immediately shot out of the room and rolled down the corridor, emitting that same ear-piercing *shriek* of noise. After a few seconds in which Ryoka shouted and Hedault calmly shook his head, the sound ended and to her surprise, the ball rolled back into the room. It sat at the enchanter's feet, calm and inactive.

It took a few minutes before the ringing had died down in Ryoka's ears to hear again. When she did, Hedault calmly picked up the ball and showed her where to press.

"It takes a rather strong force from a living hand to activate it. However, when used it will aggressively seek out any living creature in the nearby area, excluding those in a general radius of activation...if no quarry is found it will return."

"Useful!"

Ryoka shouted the words. Hedault nodded and smiled.

"Innovative. That is all of worth in the pack."

Ryoka put her finger in one ear and winced, wondering if she'd lost some of her hearing for good. She saw Reynold shaking his head and turned to Hedault.

"All of this...is this a good haul for a group that went through a dungeon? In your experience?"

He stopped and considered that, hand on the last item, the bag of holding.

"No. Some of these artifacts are indeed valuable—the shield and sword I suppose are most useful—but they are hardly impressive finds. Given the risk, I would say that this recovery is rather mediocre."

Ryoka's head lowered. Hedault smiled.

"—If you do not count the contents of this bag, that is."

Her head snapped up, and Ryoka saw a smile flash over the enchanter's face.

"You *do* have a sense of humor. Huh."

He turned away from her and carefully opened the bag.

"Given the quality of the items recovered, I had assumed the Horns of Hammerad had broken into a competent but average mage for the era, perhaps an intermediary mage in their craft. However, when I finally managed to open this bag...it is clear now that the fire trap spell that

triggered consumed many powerful artifacts. Yet this bag was completely unharmed; an appropriate measure given the artifacts contained within.”

Ryoka and Reynold held their breath as the enchanter reached into the bag. The room went silent as Hedault fished around inside and then pulled out...

Three rings and a wand. Ryoka exhaled hard as she stared down at the items in Hedault’s hand.

“Tell me looks are deceiving.”

Hedault appeared annoyed as he placed the items on the table.

“Always. These artifacts are all exceptionally valuable. Let me impress the reasons why upon you now.”

Ryoka gestured for him to go right ahead. The enchanter muttered to himself a bit and then tapped the table as he pointed to the bag.

“Firstly, the bag. It is superbly enchanted. By which I mean to say there is *no magical leakage whatsoever*. Do you understand the concept around magical interference between artifacts?”

“I get it from context. Leaky magical items conflict? Can’t have a sword and a shield if the enchantments are bad?”

“Yes. Such a combination would lead to a reaction in the worst cases, or a clash of magics which would unleash the spells, alter them in adverse ways, or simply break one or both of the enchantments. But this—this bag is perfect.”

Hedault sighed as he held it up.

“Despite the limited size—you may be able to fit twenty pounds of weight inside at most—it is stellar. A mage practicing magic may carry it without fear of any kind of magical interference.”

“Huh. Twenty pounds? Doesn’t sound that great.”

The look Hedault gave Ryoka said he was considering fitting her head in the bag and giving it a good kick.

“Bags of holding rarely contain more than a few hundred pounds of weight—and those bags are very magically unstable, let me assure you. This is the work of an artisan above my ability. You would be lucky to find another bag so well made.”

“Oh really?”

On a hunch, Ryoka pulled out her bag of holding, the one Teriarch had given her.

“This one holds a bit more than twenty pounds. I fit a bunch of chairs in it one time. I haven’t found the upper limit. Mind telling me how good this one is?”

“Hah. This is...this...”

Hedault’s voice trailed off as he took the bag from Ryoka. He peered at it, and then his eyes bulged. Ryoka snatched the bag back and smiled.

“Good to know.”

It was just a hunch, but why would a Dragon ever have a bag of holding that was less than perfect? Hedault stammered as he stared at her.

“Who made—where did you...?”

“What does this ring do?”

Ryoka lifted a ring up. Hedault had to visibly compose himself for a second—in the corner of her eye Ryoka could see Reynold writing something down. She turned with a frown, but he had tucked it into his waistcoat before she could see.

He was recording all of this down—not just the artifacts, but what she had as well! Ryoka bit her lip and made a note to have words with him afterwards. Hedault shook his head and turned back to the ring Ryoka was holding.

“It is inadvisable to touch something until an [Enchanter] has identified it. In this case, the danger is to me. Please hand it to me.”

Ryoka did. Hedault slipped the ring onto his finger and sighed, going back to his business-like self. Nevertheless, his eyes still glittered as he showed

the ring to Ryoka.

“Note the circular diamond in the center.”

“It’s large. Flawless. My g—wow. And perfectly cut.”

“Yes.”

Hedault nodded, acknowledging Ryoka’s insight into the gem itself. Ryoka had seen valuable gems—she was aware of the difference between cheap cut stones and the really important stuff. The diamond was the latter kind.

“Pure. Without faults. And large—yes. This gem acts in tandem with the metal—it is not, in fact, silver but platinum.”

“You’re kidding me. People knew how to work platinum back then?”

“Oh yes. Platinum is a very powerful metal when used for enchanting or spells...in this case, it acts as a conductor for the spell with the gem. When the ring is put on the finger and the hand is flicked like—”

Hedault paused as he put the ring on his finger. Ryoka saw Reynold duck out of the way, and she herself felt uneasy the instant she saw it go on his finger. The enchanter stared around the room and shook his head.

“...If I used it, my walls would suffer damage. I shall avoid demonstrating it now. Know that this ring can be activated and deactivated. But when activated, a flick—”

He demonstrated after taking the ring off. It was a quick snap of the wrist.

“—will send a piercing spell flying at the target. I believe it would be... difficult to aim without practice, but let me assure you that this spell far surpasses any Tier 2 or Tier 3 spell of a similar nature. It would be...around Tier 4 in potency.”

“Blood on my grave, that’s nasty.”

Reynold muttered out loud and clapped a hand to his face as both girl and mage turned to him. He colored, but Hedault nodded.

“A powerful spell, designed to cut past any quick defense. A perfect tool for an assassin—or a mage disinclined to fight fairly in a magic duel. Very

powerful.”

“So I see. And this ring?”

Ryoka pointed to one made out of wood. Hedault shrugged, losing interest.

“Very powerful. Very common. [Barkskin].”

“Do you mean literally bark for skin, or...”

“There may be some physical alterations given time, but only temporarily. The skin will indeed grow tough—not as strong as armor, but certainly far more durable which would be invaluable against daggers and to an extent, swords...but [Barkskin] also provides the wearer with a degree of cold resistance due to the thicker exterior, and of course, some users simply prefer it when travelling outdoors as the sun will provide them with energy...”

“Wait a second, you mean you’ll literally have bark for skin, as in, you can take in light like a plant?”

Hedault gave Ryoka a confused look.

“That is the implication with the spell, is it not? In any case, it is a valuable item, especially given that it is a *permanent* spell. Again, I impress on you the difference between temporary and permanent. [Stoneskin] is a powerful enchantment for instance, but I have heard of only a handful of cases where it was ever successfully imbued into an artifact.”

“Good stuff. Got it.”

“Yes, well, this ring is far more interesting.”

Hedault shook his head as he pushed the other two rings back and picked up the third. Ryoka’s eye was caught instantly by the way this one was clearly magical. It looked like it was made up of air. That was to say, it was practically invisible, but for shifting...waves in the air. It looked a lot like the shimmering that came off of pavement in the heat, only twisted into a band.

“A ring that allows the user to jump up to six times their height without consequence. Weight will affect the spell naturally, but this...”

The enchanter breathed the words out loud, eyes shining. Ryoka and Reynold blinked.

“Oh come on. *That’s* your powerful enchantment?”

Ryoka glared at Hedault. The mage looked insulted.

“This enchantment is splendidly made. And though it is not a physical enhancement, the use of gravity magic is—”

“It’s a ring of *jumping*. Tell me how that’s as useful as a ring that turns your skin into bark or shoots missiles?”

“Well, you could crush a man in armor with your foot if you put it on.”

Ryoka paused with her mouth open.

“Explain.”

“This ring does not simply allow you to ‘jump higher’. It allows you to jump higher and *maintain the weight of your fall while protecting the user*. To put it in simpler terms, this is not a ring that has a simple [Featherfall] and [Lightfoot] dual enchantment. This ring uses gravity. Thus, if a warrior in plate armor were to jump twenty feet into the air and land, the impact would—”

“Holy crap.”

“Quite. Do you understand? This is no ordinary ring. In fact, a ring of jumping completely misses the point. With it, a user could grab hold of say, a team of adventurers and leap to safety, or use it themselves to travel up a cliff without fear of falling.”

“But there are limits, right? You couldn’t just jump off a cliff and...”

Hedault raised his eyebrows. Ryoka gulped.

“Seriously?”

“The ring will come into focus the more its energies are exhausted. See, it is practically transparent? It will slowly stabilize and its true form—I believe it is a brass band—will emerge. Thus, a user will be able to calculate if it is becoming drained from usage. Although I doubt it would be drained from

anything other than a powerful impact. And it will recharge within days at most...”

It was odd. Throughout her talking with Hedault, Ryoka had just marveled at the magical items, wanting to try one or the other, but without any real desire to use any of them. What was she going to do with a sword? Well, it would be fun to chop a few things apart, but...

But now she couldn't stop staring at the ring Hedault held. She wanted it. Ryoka Griffin wanted it more than anything she'd ever seen in the world. She wanted to climb a cliff with it. Or a mountain. She wanted to jump. She wanted to *fly*.

“Okay, that one's good.”

“Relatively speaking, it *is* the second-most powerful item discovered. But this—”

Hedault sighed and picked up the wand. Ryoka's eye fixed on it. It wasn't a wand made of wood. It was metal. Iron? The dark grey—almost black metal was twisted like it had been alive, though. It was fashioned as though it were a bit of wood taken from a tree, ending with a blunted tip.

The [Enchanter] looked at Ryoka as he cradled it in his hands.

“Before I inform you as to this item's usage...I don't suppose you would consider my offer? I realize it is completely unconventional, but I feel compelled to make it.”

“Which is?”

“Allow me to pay you eighteen thousand gold pieces to purchase this wand from you. I will not make this offer again, and if you desire to accept you must not ask what this wand's usage is.”

Reynold sounded like he'd inhaled his tongue. Ryoka blinked a few times and put her hand to her ear.

“Eight...eighteen? Not just eight?”

“It is the number for silence, for not inquiring. The wand may be worth less, but this is my price. Will you take it?”

Ryoka gulped as she met Hedault's eyes. She looked at Reynold—the man was blinking rapidly as his eyes fixed on the iron wand. There was quill and inkpot balanced on his hand as he held a small book in front of him.

The young woman turned back to Hedault and sighed.

“Damnit, if you knew me...I have to know what the hell that wand is. Sorry, no deal.”

Hedault nodded. He looked visibly disappointed—Ryoka supposed that was crying and weeping on anyone else. He stroked the wand and then looked at Ryoka.

“Very well. Then, an explanation first. This wand is not metal as you might surmise. It is iron wood—it comes from a rare tree that is extinct as far as I know. But inside the wand...there is something. A core.”

“You mean, the thing that gives it magic?”

“Yes. I do not know what it is.”

“You can't tell?”

Hedault shook his head.

“It is something I have never seen before. Something...powerful. This wand is powered by the core—it is a classical wand. I suppose you do not know the difference between a classical wand and variation designed for spellcasting...? No, I see not.”

“Let me guess. One's better?”

“Substantially.”

Hedault nodded. He indicated the wand he held.

“This wand has no spell attached to it. It is...well, I suppose you could call it an aid to spellcasting, but an aid hardly encompasses...it will boost any mage's ability to cast spells immensely. Not like the modern wand. Those have cores of course, but these are almost invariably small mana stones. They are consumed with every cast of the spell embedded in the wand—you understand?”

“One’s temporary and helps cast a certain kind of spell, the other one’s good at everything and doesn’t run dry?”

“Exactly.”

Hedault nodded as he reluctantly let Ryoka inspect the wand. It was *heavy* she found—and the iron wood did indeed feel like wood. Cold, metallic wood.

“Such a wand is...valuable does not begin to describe it. Consider, please, the limits of modern construction. A—a wand made today would have to be of some high-quality wood. Perhaps meltwood, or cerabark? And the core might be unicorn hair or unicorn horn if you were so unimaginably lucky—it would be inferior to this wand by a substantial degree.”

Ryoka whistled as she held the wand.

“Ceria and Pisces are going to tear each other apart over this thing.”

“Any mage would. In fact, I advise you to take care in transporting it—it is not magically significant so a casual [Detect Magic] spell would not identify it immediately if concealed correctly, but any mage worth their salt would do almost anything to obtain such an object.”

Ryoka eyed Hedault.

“Why didn’t you lie about what it was, then? Seems odd you’d just tell me what it is after making one offer.”

The enchanter glared at her, outraged by the suggestion.

“I make my living based on my trustworthiness. I would not lie—even when sorely tempted to.”

“Sorry, sorry. It’s just—wow, this is the big one, isn’t it?”

“Yes. It is.”

Hedault grew silent as Ryoka turned the wand over in her hands. He sighed.

“Congratulations, Ryoka Griffin. I am told there are two mages in the Horns of Hammerad. One of them will benefit greatly—assuming the other does not attempt to kill them to possess this wand, that is.”

“We’ll see.”

Ryoka put the wand down and turned to Hedault. She felt lightheaded—possibly because she’d listened to him chatter on about magical artifacts for the better part of an hour. Or was it more? She couldn’t tell how long she’d been standing here.

“Was that it? You said something about repair costs...”

“Ah, yes.”

Hedault flicked his fingers and levitated the buckler up.

“This is the only object in need of repairs to function. The hilt of the sword enchanted with weight could use touching up, but that is a minor cost. Now, I estimate that this buckler can be fixed with a modicum of effort and time—say, five days? I could do it myself for a small reduction in fees.”

Ryoka nodded.

“And the price?”

Hedault tapped the buckler twice as he thought.

“I would think that the least I would ask is...one thousand and six hundred gold coins for the buckler, and four hundred...and fifty for the hilt. Now, understand that an error might occur in the repair process in which case the fee will be refunded, but the enchantment will in all likelihood be completely lost.”

He looked up and saw Ryoka had gone dead white.

“If you like, I can offer you a very good price if you would consider trading the wand—”

Outside, quite a number of streets away, Laken sighed impatiently. He was sitting with Durene and Gamel, both of whom were flicking crumbs from

their lunch and snack at some inquisitive birds who'd flown down to look.

Laken knew he should be at the inn they'd found, feeding Frostwing. And he had business at the Merchant's Guild—and the Runner's Guild—and the Adventurer's Guild. But he was waiting here for Ryoka Griffin.

“Where *is* she? I wonder if something's happened?”

Across the city, one of the overworked [Receptionists] in the Mage's Guild sighed long and hard as he got another message in. This one was addressed to a name he'd had cause to curse in the last few days.

He neatly took note of it, recording the sender and the addressee.

To: Ryoka Griffin

From: Erin Solstice.

This was the first message from this sender, but he had messages from...the [Receptionist] consulted the sheet out of idle curiosity.

Ah yes. From Krshia Silverfang, Selys Shivertail, Klbkch (no last name given), Lyonette (no last name given), Ceria Springwalker, Pisces (no last name given), and now Erin Solstice.

He wished she would turn up.

And last, but certainly not least, the female [Receptionist] at the Runner's Guild grimly stopped talking with one of the Runners who'd come in. She was going off-duty for the day, but she left a message for all [Receptionists] on duty. She had a message for Ryoka Griffin too, and she was sure the girl wasn't going to like it.

And outside, the snow began to fall. The winter was more than half-over. It had been a long one, but the longest day of the year was fast approaching. After that, the snows would linger for a while, but then melt.

Winter was ending. But there was a lot to do first. And much of it turned on a young woman who was currently talking about payment plans with an [Enchanter].

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“Tomorrow, then. Or sooner if I can get a hold of the Horns of Hammerad by mage spell.”

“Very well. Please confine your visiting hours between dawn and sunset.”

That seemed like a fairly easy request, so Ryoka nodded to Hedault as she and Reynold left his house. She supposed that without clocks, appointments were a little harder to keep.

The [Enchanter] stood in his living room and gestured to make the front door swing open. Ryoka saw Reynold stop to bow and thank him. She was almost out the door, having said her goodbyes. From the look on Hedault’s face as he stared at the [Butler], he preferred succinct conversations.

Ryoka paused as she stepped towards the door and turned back to Hedault.

“One last question. Are any of your other artifacts for sale?”

She nodded to a mace neatly hung on a wall plaque. Hedault nodded.

“These are...competent examples of my craft, or artifacts I have purchased for study. I have a small selection of items that I may be willing to sell.”

“Got it. See you later.”

The young woman walked out of the door, Reynold following with another polite farewell. Once she was outside, Ryoka took one look at the sun and cursed.

“How long was I in there?”

“Around an hour an a half by my count, Miss Ryoka.”

Reynold stepped smoothly over to her side as the door silently closed behind them. Ryoka sighed.

“Well shit. Okay, I guess I need to run. Thanks for bringing me here, Reynold.”

“My pleasure, Miss Ryoka.”

“I don’t have anything in particular to do.”

“I see.”

“...You can go now.”

Ryoka stared at Reynold. The [Butler] did not move. He stood politely at attention by her side, back perfectly straight. He seemed to be attracting approving glances from a lot of the passersby, and not just because he looked good in a suit. These upstanding citizens probably employed or wanted to employ a man like Reynold, or rather, a [Butler] like Reynold. Then again, Ryoka hadn’t ever seen a Gnoll [Butler] or a Drake [Manservant]. Perhaps they didn’t take to it as well?

She coughed as she began walking down the street. Reynold followed her.

“I don’t need your help, Reynold. How can I put this politely...? Piss off.”

“I’m afraid I cannot do that, Miss Griffin. My orders were to escort you around the city.”

“And I don’t need an escort anymore. Hold on—”

The young woman’s eyes narrowed as she put the pieces together.

“Magnolia told you to follow me everywhere, didn’t she?”

“That is correct, Miss. I am afraid my orders regarding you were quite specific. I must accompany you everywhere. On that note, shall we return to the plaza? I believe we are late for your meeting.”

The young woman and butler had been striding quickly down the street towards that very spot, where Ryoka had promised to meet Laken. But Ryoka stopped dead in her tracks and turned around.

“You bastard.”

The man’s expression didn’t change. He calmly met Ryoka’s eyes.

“I did not follow you, Miss Ryoka. But I am not the only person in Lady Reinhart’s employ who was given orders regarding you. Happily, the young

man you met appears to be still sitting in the plaza, although he is growing restless. May I suggest we continue walking?”

Ryoka did, although now she was ready to do violence. Internally she was cursing. She should have realized Magnolia would set watchers on her!

“Why are you being obvious about spying on me? If you can set watchers so easily, why bother with an escort at all?”

Reynold’s eyebrows rose slightly.

“Lady Reinhart expected you to put the pieces together, Miss Ryoka. I believe this is her way of assisting you—again, in her own way. But she did tell me to be open about her orders if you asked.”

“So I don’t spook and run, is that it?”

“I would not dare to make such an assumption, Miss.”

“I’ll bet.”

For a second, just a second, Ryoka thought about killing Reynold and dumping his body in a ditch somewhere. But of course, Magnolia would know if Ryoka killed her butler. And where would Ryoka find a handy ditch anyways? What about digging a grave? That would be hell in the snow, and Ryoka would have to lure Reynold far out into the countryside to do that...

It was just a passing thought. But it was tempting. She was furious, but Ryoka was already worrying about Laken. She’d given him away, hadn’t she? But he might just be another person from her world, hardly important—the key would be making sure Magnolia’s servants saw it that way.

She turned her head as Reynold kept pace with her down the street.

“Out of curiosity...if I knock you out, how badly do you think Lady Magnolia would react?”

Again, the [Butler]’s face didn’t twitch. It must have been a Skill.

“If you wish to try, I am afraid you may well succeed. I must tell you however that I *am* under orders.”

“Oh really?”

“Yes. Miss Ressa gave me precise instructions as to what I should do if you offered me violence, Miss Ryoka.”

“Ressa?”

Ryoka looked over at Reynold. He just stared at her. Slowly, Ryoka unclenched the fist she’d made.

“I really hate your boss, Reynold.”

“I believe the feeling is mutual, Miss Ryoka. I see we have stopped again. Shall we proceed?”

“Sure. Remind me to kick your ass when I’m done here, Reynold?”

“I shall make a note of it.”

In general, I’d say I’m a pretty patient guy. Well, I do like to keep myself busy, but being blind means that sometimes you’ve just got to wait and think about what you’re going to do next.

For instance, if you’ve lost your walking cane, and you’re in an unfamiliar place, well, you’d better stop and think or you might walk straight into a car. I’ve done that only once before, but believe me, patience is a life saver.

I know better than to hurry things along. There’s a time for action, but if it’s not that time, you might as well take it slow.

Still, I don’t like waiting *too* long. I shift impatiently on the bench as Durene and Gamel sit next to me. Well, I say sit, but Durene is too big to really share the bench with so she’s sitting on the ground and Gamel seems determined to stand at attention like some kind of personal bodyguard.

Lunch is done. We’ve all had a snack—some very fine Gnollish cooking, which came in the form of a marinated mix of beef and vegetables drizzled in spicy sauce. I was tickled to learn that instead of disposable paper plates,

vendors in this city use cheap ceramics. We pay more for the dishes of course, but we get it back if we return our bowls undamaged.

Gamel bought the food and returned the dishes once we were done. He insisted—I would have liked him to rest since he’s been on his feet all day, but he wants to be useful.

Now I turn to him and sense him snap to attention. I don’t have to hear it; I just know he’s standing straighter and turning to face me. It’s so odd. Gamel is only a few years younger than I am, but he thinks I have all the answers.

That’s a dangerous belief. I frown, but put that issue aside for far later. Right now I only have one question.

“Do you see Ryoka, Durene? Gamel?”

“I don’t see anyone, Laken. I mean, there are a lot of people, but—”

“I don’t see any Runner with dark skin, sire.”

“Darn. Where could she be?”

A thousand and one answers come to mind. The first of which is that this Ryoka girl is setting us up for a trap and by waiting, I’ve walked us all into it. I sigh and stand up.

“Well, we’ve waited long enough. Let’s go.”

I grab my walking cane and reach out for Durene, but feel her shift, turn as she touches my hand.

“I—wait, I see her, Laken! That’s her alright!”

I stiffen. I can’t see where Ryoka is coming from, but Durene faces me the right way. I hear Gamel draw in his breath.

“What is it?”

“She’s not alone, Laken.”

Immediately, the paranoid part of me starts freaking out. But I keep my voice calm. A leader can’t look nervous. That probably goes triple for an [Emperor], shoddy one though I may be.

“Who is with her?”

“A...I don’t know. What kind of man is that, Gamel? He looks odd.”

“Odd?”

“Yes, Emper—Mister Laken. He has, well, fancy clothes on. They’re all black and white, and he has a bow tie at his neck. He looks like a rich man’s servant, sir.”

“A rich man’s servant...”

I frown. I almost imagine a man in a prison uniform when Gamel says black and white clothes. But they have stripes, don’t they? I don’t know. I think I read about that in a book somewhere, but I haven’t really read a description of prison uniforms in a long time. I always imagine people in that sort of clothing when I listen to news stories about escaped convicts and trials, though.

A servant, though...why would Ryoka have one of those?

“He’s with her?”

“Yes, and they’re—”

Durene breaks off as I hear someone walk towards me. There’s a moment of hesitation as I feel Durene let go of my hand and move. I can’t tell what’s happened, but then I hear the girl named Ryoka speak.

“Laken? I’m here.”

“Ah, Ryoka Griffin? Is that you?”

I don’t know what’s going on, but I opt for pleasant surprise. I listen very carefully to her as she replies.

“Yes. Sorry I’m late. Something came up. I—well, sorry.”

She sounds tense. And worried. Not at all like she did while talking to me before. That was a different sort of tense. This sounds like anxiety in her tone, which means that...

I think quickly and nod, putting a smile on my face.

“Of course. Thank you for coming back. Why don’t we chat over by the benches, assuming they’re not all taken?”

I turn and hear Ryoka cough.

“Your—friend is in the way.”

“Durene? Please let Ryoka past.”

“Okay.”

Shuffling feet. Then—I hear a man’s voice.

“Ah, pardon me Miss Durene, is it? I would like to introduce myself, if you would permit it.”

“Who are you?”

Ryoka’s voice.

“This is Reynold, Laken. He’s my escort. He’s a friend. A—hold on, let me look this up.”

Silence, shuffling. I hear Durene and Gamel murmur in surprise, but have no idea what Ryoka is doing. So I turn to the man named Reynold.

“Hello. I’m pleased to make your acquaintance. Are you Ryoka’s friend?”

“Not as of such, sir. I—I am a—pardon me, but please accept my most profuse apologies to greet you so rudely. Allow me to introduce myself as Reynold Ferusdam, a humble servant in the employ of Lady Magnolia Reinhart.”

I hear a gasp from Durene and a sound from Ryoka. It’s short, but it makes me think this Reynold fellow has done something. I hold still, but sense nothing.

“Please excuse my rudeness, sir.”

“Not...at all.”

I don’t blink, because I keep my eyelids closed all the time, but I am taken aback. Lady who? What’s this Reynold fellow got to do with Ryoka and why is he acting so formal? Wait a minute. I think I know what’s going on.

There are a number of ways I could reply. I opt for more genuine interest. I smile and extend my hand.

“Oh? Pleased to meet you. May I assume you are a—a [Manservant] or [Butler] of some sort?”

“Indeed, milo—Mister Laken, that is correct. I am a [Butler] currently given the task of escorting Miss Ryoka around the city.”

I feel a light hand—gloved—shake mine and then withdraw. I can tell this man Reynold is wearing some kind of cologne. Well now, I think I understand his odd reaction. Is there a way to make use of it? Perhaps not, but I also fear it might be giving me away a bit.

Someone clears her throat next to me. I hear Ryoka draw closer.

“Goddamn stupid...okay, I think I have it. Laken, Reynold is a friend of a friend. I know Lady Magnolia Reinhart—she’s one of the Five Families in the continent as I’m sure you know, a very powerful [Lady]—and she’s sent Reynold to help me out because I know her. Reynold is a friend. He’s uh—damnit. *Freund aber Spion. Achtung. Sag nichts. Verstehst du mich?*”

This is why having my eyes closed all the time helps. They don’t narrow and I keep perfect control of my voice.

“Ja.”

So that’s how it is? I smile at Ryoka.

“It’s good to meet someone else who speaks a different language.”

“Yes, it is. Around here everyone speaks English. Everyone. Weird, isn’t it?”

There’s a note of humor in her tone. I shrug lightly and turn towards Durene.

“I’m sorry, Durene, Gamel. I haven’t introduced you, have I? This is Ryoka—I met her today, but we, ah, come from the same place. I think of her as a friend, and I hope you will as well. I think she and Mister Reynold might be able to help us while we’re here.”

I hear people moving and murmuring greetings.

“Hello. My name is Durene. I’m Laken’s friend.”

“Charmed.”

Is it me, or is there not a lot of friendliness in Durene’s tone? I hear Ryoka mutter something and shift—were they shaking hands or something? But then Reynold walks over and I practically feel Durene flush. Listening to her stammer, it sounds like he bowed or kissed her hand.

Well now. Smiling a bit, I sit with Ryoka on the bench. Everyone else stands.

“So why are you here?”

Ryoka’s tone is warning, but I ignore it. Honesty. You can do a lot with honesty, especially when you pair it with omission.

“It’s a long story. Durene and Gamel and I are all from Riverfarm, a small village to the...east, I think. We’ve come here because an avalanche hit the village a few days ago. A good number of people died, and the rest are in trouble since the avalanche wiped out a lot of their provisions for the winter. Not to mention, there’s a danger of monsters, bandit attacks...”

I hear an indrawn breath. So, Ryoka really had no idea why I was here? She shifts on the bench next to me and sounds pained.

“That’s not good. But how are you going to get all those supplies? Buying all that in the winter would cost a small fortune, and that’s without hiring a [Guard] or two.”

“Indeed, sir. Would the other villages be able to assist you? A neighboring town or city, perhaps? Some provinces have local [Lords] or [Ladies] who take care of their subjects, but I’m afraid Riverfarm is not a claimed holding.”

I shake my head at the questions.

“Money isn’t an issue. It’s finding a good supplier of food and a trustworthy adventuring team I’m struggling a bit with. Reynold, you seem to know your way around this city—would you answer a few questions for me?”

“I should be delighted to, sir.”

“Good!”

I smile, and feel Ryoka shift on the bench again. But if she thinks I’ve said too much, she doesn’t do anything. I gather my thoughts. I really only need a few questions answered for the moment.

“Tell me, my good man—”

God, I sound like a pretentious idiot. It must be because I’m imagining a real [Butler] standing in front of me. I cough and adjust my tone.

“—I’m afraid I’m new to the city. To this area, really. I’d love to know more about this city. Is Invril an independent city-state? I’ve heard those are common around here, rather than nations. Who rules a place like this? A mayor?”

“Invril, sir Laken? This city does have an elected leader—Regisand Curle is the appointed [Mayor] for the moment. However, if I may say so, he is more of an administrator than one to set policy.”

“Fascinating. So if I were to ask who the real power behind the throne is...?”

“That would be Lady Reinhart, my employer, sir. Well, I should say Lady Magnolia Reinhart has the power to persuade the city to adopt new policies or to ah, see her point of view, but she rarely uses such authority. Day-to-day it’s usually just the Guilds and various nobles infighting, sir.”

“Really? The Guilds? No, wait—I see. I’ve heard of the Runner’s Guild, Adventurer’s Guild, the Merchant’s Guilds, and so on. How much power do they wield, politically and economically, I mean? Actually, do they have any standing forces of their own? And how would you compare that to the power of, oh, say, the average landed gentry, an average [Lord]?”

I hear Reynold gulp, but he replies quickly.

“The Guilds are a powerful force in any city, sir, although I would wager most [Lords] have just as much authority in their own way. Well, the average [Lord] doesn’t have the coin to match a large Guild, but he does have his own standing forces, and the Guilds usually don’t actively pick their battles. If it comes to blows they hire mercenaries or fight themselves

if it's the Adventurer or Runner's Guild, but it's rare for things to get that bad. Mostly, the worse that happens is someone gets assassinated, or finds themselves out of work or disgraced."

"I see. Hm. So, correct me if I'm wrong, but a [Merchant] would have a bit of influence on their own, but only the most wealthy ones would be put on the same footing as one of the nobility. Is that right?"

"To an extent, sir. There's an old saying in the north—'even a [Shopkeeper] can sell a [Lord]'. The poorest [Trader] has friends, and they can boycott a [Lord] who's wronged him, or lend money to a [Baroness] who needs it for a gala."

Politics. I shake my head.

"Sounds like a mess. I had no idea it was this complicated around here."

Ryoka comments sourly next to me. I'm in agreement with her.

"Is it like this everywhere, Reynold?"

"I do believe so. In Invrisil, First Landing—all the major cities have a hand in the politics of the continent, sir. [Lords] and [Ladies] of the Five Families maneuver with each other while [Shopkeepers] and [Merchants] play the same game on a smaller level. I've heard the Drakes in the south do much the same thing, although I've heard their version of things is far more direct and...material. But politics is the lifeblood of every continent."

As in our world, so too in this. I incline my head in his direction.

"Well, thank you. That's all I needed to know."

So, if you're a high-level person with a lot of coin—or you're nobility, or you're part of a big Guild you're a mover and a shaker, but everyone else is subject to the power plays of the continent. I wonder what effect my actions might have, if any?

I stand up.

"If the Guilds have power, they're the ones I need to go to. I was thinking of going to the Runner's Guild—Ryoka, Durene tells me you look like a Runner. Do you know if they'd be able to get supplies out to Riverfarm? It's

a ways away, and I'd need a lot of supplies. I don't think a few people can carry all that—how much would it cost to hire, say, fifty people? Or do the Runner's Guild have wagons?"

"They've got bags of holding."

I smile, delighted.

"No way. In that case, how fast could they travel, oh, thirty miles?"

Ryoka pauses.

"If you had the coin, you could have someone in Riverfarm within the hour I'll bet. But...don't go to the Runner's Guild."

"Why not?"

Gamel sounds astounded. It takes Ryoka another minute to reply.

"They've got bags of holding and they're a lot faster, yeah. But if you need to buy supplies as well as have them delivered, the Merchant Guild might be able to cut you a better deal. They're rivals with the Runners—they're slow, but if you're hiring protection as well, it'll be cheaper."

"Huh."

Not something I'd expect to hear from a Runner, but I'm grateful for the advice. I smile around at everyone.

"I suppose that's our destination, then. Durene, Gamel, we're going to the Merchant's Guild. I don't suppose you'd like to join us, Ryoka, Reynold?"

"I am bound to escort Miss Ryoka wherever she travels. It would be my pleasure to accompany you if she so chooses."

"...Yeah, I'll go. I know where the Guild is—it's a few blocks away from here."

"I'll help take Laken, Miss Ryoka."

Durene's voice comes from next to me. She sounds...a bit possessive. But Ryoka doesn't budge.

"I've led blind people before."

So saying, she takes my hand. I'm surprised, but I think quickly.

"It's okay, Durene. I'll walk with Ryoka for a bit. You can see the sights while we chat."

"But—okay, Laken."

I hear the hurt tone in Durene's voice, but Ryoka pulls at my hand and then we're off. It must be an odd sight as she leads me out of the plaza. I know Gamel, Reynold and Durene are keeping pace with us because I hear Reynold speaking to them, but then Ryoka begins talking.

"Is she your girlfriend or something?"

"Who?"

"The—Durene. She acts like you two are a couple."

"We are a couple."

"What?"

I speak sharply.

"Is there something wrong with that?"

Hesitation. Ryoka sounds guilty.

"No. I—damn it, sorry. I'm just surprised."

I say nothing in response. After a moment, Ryoka sighs.

"Sorry. She seems protective. She nearly broke my fingers when I shook her hand."

"Really?"

"She thinks I'm a threat."

"You did come out of nowhere. And even if you are from my world, that doesn't mean much to Durene."

Ryoka pauses, and I nearly run into her. I sense her turn.

"You *told* her you're from another world?"

“Of course. I trust her.”

“—Okay. Fine. Sure. You told her. Does anyone else know you’re from another world? That Gamel guy, for instance?”

“No. Have *you* told anyone? Why is that Reynold fellow following you about?”

“He’s a servant of Lady Magnolia. And *she* knows. In fact, she knows everything. Her servants followed me—they were probably listening to us when we spoke the first time, and they’re probably listening now. Keep that in mind.”

“I will. But if they’re, ah, ‘friends but spies’, should I trust them or not?”

“...I don’t know. Magnolia’s not evil, but she’s not nice either. She might not care you’re from another world—she’s found other people like us.”

“Really? How many? Where were they?”

Ryoka gives my hand a squeeze.

“Just a few. Looks like a few other people got pulled to this continent. Maybe we all got hit by a rogue spell or something. There are five or six kids around our age—maybe a few years younger. But that’s all I know.”

Another squeeze. I gently tighten my fingers to let her know I understand. So Magnolia knows a lot, but not everything? How many of us *are* there? Why are we here?

I guess that’s a bad topic, so I go back to Magnolia.

“What’s she like? If she hires [Butlers], can I assume she’s rich?”

“Oh yeah. She’s one of the Five Families—they’re the richest nobles on the continent. She’s a [Lady] with an army of servants, tons of magical artifacts, a magical horseless carriage...”

“Are you serious? First bags of holding, now magical automobiles—are you going to tell me adventurers run around with flaming swords and shields of wonder?”

“Hah. Close. Try flaming daggers. But seriously—watch out for Magnolia. She might appear friendly and nice, but she’s devious. Imagine her as a—a—do you, I mean, did you watch Game of Thrones back home?”

I twitch a bit, but keep walking.

“I did. Watch is a bit strong, but I did a lot of listening to audiobooks and I listened to some episodes with visual description turned on.”

“Then imagine her as a Daenerys except older.”

“Sort of like Cersei Lannister?”

“Sort of. But...smarter. Less arrogant. Daenerys is a better analogy, especially given that she has one big thing in common with her. I mean, not as a mother, but a friend. And she’s twice as cunning as both Daenerys and Cersei put together—and she’s bold like Catelyn Stark, got it?”

“I get it. And she knows about you, or rather, us?”

“About everyone. She’s met people...like us, before. And she knows about one of my friends. Her name is Erin Solstice. She lives far south of here, in Liscor. She’s an [Innkeeper]...I’d like you to meet her sometime.”

“I’d be delighted. But I do have to help Riverfarm.”

“The village? Why? Because Durene lives there?”

“Yes. And because they’re good people. Well, fairly good. They’ll starve or die without help.”

“And you can do it?”

“I think so. I wasn’t expecting to meet someone from another world, though.”

“Neither was I. I just heard you speaking German and—look, I’m sorry I got you mixed up in this.”

I shrug fractionally.

“Politics. I’d get involved sooner or later, especially considering...well, let’s just say that having your friend here and learning a bit about the city

might be helpful. If this Lady Magnolia really is a friend to the people, I think she'd approve of what we're doing here."

Ryoka's quick pace falters. I hear her take a breath as people shout at a rude wagon driver ahead of us.

"About buying supplies. Do you need help with getting supplies for this village of yours? If you need coin I...damnit, I've got some, but—"

"I'll be fine. Trust me."

Silence. Then Ryoka stops.

"I'll try."

I tap the ground experimentally with my walking stick, but feel no difference in the paving stone around me. Not that I really expected it.

"We're in front of the Merchant's Guild? How does it look?"

"Big. Fancy. They went all out on the architecture around here. Lots of gold paint."

There's a sneer in Ryoka's voice. I hear the others catch up, and then Durene speaks.

"Laken! We're in front of the Merchant's Guild!"

Is it just me, or is she right between me and Ryoka? I smile up at her.

"I know. Ryoka, can you give us a second? I want to talk with Durene before we..."

"Got it. Hey Reynold, come over here."

They retreat. I'm left alone with Durene and Gamel, although he's standing further away. I whisper up to Durene.

"Do you not like Ryoka?"

"I—I don't trust her, Laken. Are you sure she's someone you know?"

"I think I can trust her. But tell me, is there anything I missed back in the plaza? When that man Reynold introduced himself, you and Gamel made a

noise.”

“Yeah! When he was speaking he—he *bowed* to you, Laken! He bowed really low!”

“As one would to a...someone like me?”

“Someone like—oh, yeah!”

“Interesting. Don’t say anything about it for now, okay? It’s a secret. Tell Gamel that.”

“Okay Laken. But...”

I can practically see Durene’s face, upset with confusion and nerves.

“What’s going on? This is all so sudden! What are we going to do in the Merchant’s Guild, hire a bunch of wagons?”

“Close. I actually think we can get done most of what we need to while we’re in there. It’s going to be complex, Durene. But we can handle it. All you need to do is look impressive. I think you can do that.”

“But what should I do? I don’t know anything about—money or stuff like that. Are you sure I should come in with you?”

“What, and leave me alone? I need you, Durene. Will you come with me?”

“Yes.”

It’s a response without a second of hesitation behind it. Just one word, but it blows away my self-doubt and my own fears. I smile as Durene squeezes my hand with the utmost care. She’s with me, and she’s all the help I’ll need. How could I ask for more?

And yet, I have more. Gamel is right beside us, faithfully going along with all of this although he clearly doesn’t understand what I’m thinking. He trusts me. He’s loyal.

What an odd thought. But he is my subject and I’ll do right by him.

So it’s not Laken the confused guy who stops in front of the Merchant’s Guild, it’s Laken the [Emperor]. He’s listened and heard all of what’s going

on and he has a good idea of the situation he's in. And he has a plan.

I gesture for Gamel to come over, and we huddle together in front of the Merchant's Guild as I explain what I want to do. Politics. [Lords] and [Ladies] and Guilds and [Merchants]. Well, I'm an [Emperor] so I trump all of them. I smile as I speak to my two followers, my two subjects, my two friends.

"Okay you two, here's what we're going to do. Durene, I want you to open the doors like this when we go in..."

As the blind young man known as Laken stood with his two friends, Ryoka waited a few feet down the street with Reynold. She pulled something out of her pocket—an iPhone—and tapped on the screen.

Ryoka glanced down at her iPhone and closed the encyclopedia app she had been using. It had been a long, long time since she'd last used it but she was glad to know that it could still work offline.

"Guess it's not a waste of gigabytes after all."

She tucked it away in her pocket and sighed. What a mess. She had no idea what Laken was about to do, but from the way the villager and half-Troll girl were reacting, it was going to be surprising.

"I have no idea what the hell is going on."

"Ye never do."

Ivolethe poked her head out of Ryoka's belt pouch, chewing on a walnut. She was actually eating the shell as well as the nut itself. Ryoka eyed the small blue faerie. She wondered if Laken could hear Ivolethe like Erin

could. If so, that might be a better way of letting him know important details.

But what did he really need to know? Everything Ryoka knew about the other people scattered across the world, about Erin and the dangers of the Antinium and so on—that was for a much longer conversation, later. Right now she could only trust he wouldn't blurt out anything important.

She didn't think he would, honestly. She was surprised by how fast he'd caught on to everything.

“At least I got the message to him. Thank god for monoglottism in this world.”

Ryoka saw Ivolethe's small head turn towards her and laugh.

“Hah! I heard thy terrible attempt at language. *Deine Aussprache ist schrecklich.*”

Ryoka scowled down at her belt.

“How the hell do you know what I—no, don't tell me. I guess you lot were all over Europe back in the day, huh?”

“I travelled to many lands, and learned many tongues! You sound as if you were speaking with mud and worms in your mouth!”

“Yeah, yeah.”

Ryoka scowled and closed the belt pouch over Ivolethe, ignoring the tiny faerie's shout. She turned her head slightly, and regarded Reynold.

She hadn't had time to ask, but she was intensely curious to know why he'd bowed like he had when meeting Laken. The man was still pale and shaking a bit even after their short walk.

“Hey Reynold. What was that, back there?”

The [Butler] jumped as if Ryoka had shouted in his ear. He jerked his eyes away from Laken, and stared at Ryoka. Then he stepped over and hissed at her, completely forgetting about politeness or decorum.

“Who *is* that man?”

“Laken? I have no idea.”

“Don’t give me that! He is—I’ve never felt—”

Reynold’s cheeks were flushed. He kept staring at Laken.

“What did you feel?”

Ryoka eyed him closely. Reynold opened his mouth and shook his head.

“He was like—I suppose it was like standing before Lady Reinhart, or Lord Veltras. One of the high nobility, Ryoka. Only more intense. It’s a sense most [Servants] have—I felt as though I should have been prostrating myself at his feet.”

“Really?”

The young woman’s eyes narrowed. She stared at Laken and saw him step back from the huddle with Durene and Gamel. Durene carefully took his hand and they began moving towards the Merchant’s Guild.

“Hold on, here we go. Let’s see what he’s about to do.”

This was what Ryoka saw. She saw Durene march up to the doors and then let go of Laken. He grabbed hold of Gamel’s shirt instead, and waited as Durene stood in front of the two ornate double doors.

She attracted attention. For all the half-Troll girl was wearing rough clothing, Ryoka had to admit that she was impressive. Durene was the tallest person around, and when she stood tall and didn’t slouch she was a true giant. She grabbed hold of the door handles and flung the doors wide open.

“Now *that’s* an entrance.”

Ryoka commented as she followed Laken and the others inside. The dramatic opening had made the entire Merchant's Guild go silent, or maybe it was seeing Durene come striding through the doorway. Either way, suddenly all eyes were on Laken and Durene and Gamel.

No, they were all on Laken. For all of Durene's height, there was something about the blind man that drew the eye. Ryoka blinked and rubbed at her own eyes as she stared at his back. Was he...taller? No, but he seemed like it.

What was going on? She frowned hard as Laken walked forwards.

The Merchant's Guild was as gaudy and plush on the inside as it was on the outside. It had [Receptionists] but other counters as well, places to exchange coin, sell goods, take out loans, and so on. Impressive brass scales were a fixture of the room, as well as other handy measuring tools and things like abacuses—all aids to calculating the worth of an item down to the last copper coin.

Ryoka expected Laken to march up right to one of the receptionist's desks, but he didn't do that. He took ten steps into the room and then stopped there. With all eyes on him and his companions Laken stopped and waited as Durene bent down to whisper in his ear.

"Of course. He can't see."

Ryoka murmured the words. It was necessary for Laken, but the effect it caused was impressive. There he was, standing in the center of a whirlpool of attention, waiting. The effect was also immediate.

It wasn't a lowly [Receptionist] that came hurrying towards Laken across the floor, but a balding, portly man that Ryoka pegged as a [Merchant] or some higher Guild official. She saw him stop as Durene turned to block him, and then hurry forwards and seize Laken's hand. After a few moments of discussion, they walked over to some chairs and a table set to one side of the room.

That was ordinary. But Laken was not. He sat politely across from the [Merchant], eyes closed, smiling as he talked. And Durene stood

protectively next to him, a half-Troll bodyguard while Gamel stood on the other side, looking fiercely proud despite his simple clothing.

What was going on? Who was that man? Why did he catch the eye so? Ryoka heard the murmuring, and saw the people waiting in line or doing business sneaking glances over at Laken as the guild slowly began to get back to business. Some people took seats at tables next to Laken's, others simply wandered over as they chatted quietly.

It was a Skill, or something about Laken. Ryoka watched, arms folded by the doors as Reynold scribbled in his notebook furiously. Laken sat and smiled as he talked to the [Merchant], radiating confidence like a beacon.

He did nothing dramatic, and his words were inaudible except to the people closest to him. And yet, he had a presence that weighed down on his surroundings and dragged every eye to where he sat. Slowly, the room began to revolve around him.

I sit with the [Merchant] named Meref in the center of his guild and thank god that they have padded seats in here. The bench in the park wasn't bad, but after more than an hour of sitting on its hard surface, I could use some support for my backside.

Especially because I have the feeling I'll be here for a while. I sit with my back straight in the chair, hearing quiet voices around me, people haggling, or buying goods in bulk, negotiating deliveries to other cities.

Doing business, in short. It's not distracting to me, and I can tune it out, but it's a reminder that we're sitting in the open, in the center of the guild.

"Again, Mister Laken, I would be quite happy to seat you in a private room to discuss any business. I'm sure a man such as yourself might prefer the privacy."

"I feel quite comfortable conducting my affairs out in the open, Mister Meref. I have nothing to hide, after all."

The Merchant's Guild has private rooms of course, although they might not be that private. I'd bet some of them have listening spells or peepholes...I smile in the general direction of the merchant. I hear him swallow, and then speak.

"Well then, I'm happy to get down to business. What ah, did you say the nature of your visit was about? Did I hear your—your helper correctly when she said you wanted to place a big order?"

"Indeed, Mister Merec. A large order. I would like to purchase food, supplies, livestock, tools, and so on for a village of around a hundred people. Of course, not just for one meal or two—I'd like to make a purchase that will last them the rest of the winter. To that end, I'd like to hire at least...twelve wagons, I suppose, and the appropriate guards to protect such a delivery. I was thinking at least two teams of adventurers might do."

I don't quite hear Merec inhale his tongue, but he comes close.

"S-supplies? For a village? May I ask what this is about, sir?"

"Riverfarm, my good man, Riverfarm."

"Where...? I'm sorry, Mister Laken, but I've never heard of such a village."

"Really? You haven't? But their cabbage exports are a local keystone of the markets!"

I try to sound upset, but the truth is I'm laughing inside. I steeple my fingers and lean forwards over the table.

"I happen to be a great friend of the villagers there, Mister Merec. You may not have heard, but an avalanche hit the village and surrounding region not three days past. It was a tragedy, and many lives were lost."

"I—I had heard something of the kind, sir. So these goods are for the village?"

"Yes indeed. I'm in rather a hurry, so if you could have the wagons loaded and sent out in, oh, an hour's time that would be best."

"I—well, hold on now."

Merec tries to take back command of the situation. I hear saliva moving as he pauses, and then his tone becomes genial, professionally good-humored.

“We would love to fulfill your request, Mister Laken. But before we talk details, may I ask how you intend to pay for all of this? I hesitate to ask, but with such a huge transaction in mind—”

“Of course! Let’s not beat around the bushes, Merec!”

I raise my voice and feel the man wince. People around me go silent as I sit taller in my chair.

“Riverfarm needs aid, Mister Merec. Posthaste! Today, if it can be managed! I came to the Merchant’s Guild because I was told you could help me better than the Runner’s Guild.”

“Well, that’s certainly true, sir. We have the goods—those Runners would have to come to *us* for supplies. But about payment—”

I wave an impatient hand at him.

“Money is no object. Durene, would you please put the bag on the table so Mister Merec can see it?”

I hear Durene fiddle with her belt, and then a heavy *thump*. Merec’s chair screeches back, and then I hear him and voices around him gasp and exclaim.

“Dead gods!”

“Is that—”

“Are these gems, sir? And this—”

“I’m afraid I didn’t have time to convert it all into gold—but I believe exchanging gemstones is one of the functions of your guild, isn’t it? Well, I’ll leave sorting out the exact worth till later, but I assume this will be adequate?”

“Ah—ah—”

I think I broke the poor man. I tap a foot on the ground until Merec manages to speak again.

“Of course. Of course—you there! Bring over some chairs for Mister Laken’s escorts, now! And have drinks sent for—may I offer you some refreshments, Mister Laken?”

“I wouldn’t say no, but I *am* in a hurry, Mister Meref.”

“Yes, sir. I completely—thank you. There’s just one matter I must attend to. I’m terribly sorry, but in cases like this—would you mind taking an oath on a truth spell? It’s just that in cases like this where we cannot be sure where this money has come from—”

“Are you accusing me of having stolen that money?”

I interject a note of frank incredulity into my tone. Durene makes an ominous noise.

“Laken *didn’t* steal that. All of this is his!”

Meref makes a very small sound, and I imagine him shrinking back as Durene towers over him.

“No, of course...it’s just a matter of protocol, see? I’d never question—please, Mister Laken—”

“It’s okay, Durene.”

I wave a hand at her and hear her step back. I smile brightly at Meref.

“I understand completely. Can I assume you have a stone of some sort I’d put my hand on?”

“Yes sir. It’s right here...if you just keep it close to your person, it will shine and uh, tell the truth.”

“Very well. In that case, allow me to go a step further so I may clarify matters.”

I reach out and find the stone on the table after a few seconds of searching. I pull it closer and speak carefully.

“This money is mine.”

I hear a murmur as the stone presumably lights up. I trust that I'm not being made out to be a liar and go on.

"I am a relative newcomer to this land, but I am deeply concerned with the wellbeing of the people of Riverfarm, who took me in and offered me hospitality during my time of need. My wealth comes from my, ah, class. It was not stolen from anyone to the best of my knowledge, and it is mine by right."

More murmuring. I lift my hand away from the stone.

"I trust that satisfies your questions, Mister Merec?"

"It does indeed, sir. I apologize most sincerely for the inconvenience, but—ah—may I ask what your class is?"

"You may ask, but I may not answer."

I smile at Merec. I hear him hesitate.

"You wouldn't happen to be of the aristocracy, sir? Forgive my curiosity, but it's very rare to have someone of your status in our guild. Most nobles send servants you see..."

I just smile. No reply. But I hear the small intake of breath, and know the crystal has probably changed color again. Tricky, that. But all to the better. An [Emperor] is the highest form of nobility, after all. I gently push the stone back across the table just to be sure I don't trigger it again.

"Well then, now that the truth has been established, let us go back to business. Food, Mister Merec."

"Of course! We can have a shipment prepared—at a very reasonable price, as well. Ah—however, I hate to mention this, but at this point in the year grain and meat and so on *is* very dear. I'm afraid you'll be paying quite the steep rate for all of this..."

I raise a hand and the man falls silent.

"As I've said, money is no object. I know you would not cheat me or drive up the price unfairly, Mister Merec."

"I would *never*—"

“I know. I don’t need a Skill, spell, or even eyes to see that. An honest price—and coin in your pockets for work well done—is all I need. I don’t fear being lied to, you see.”

“You...don’t?”

“Of course not. You see, liars and cheats have a way of revealing themselves to me, Merec. Which is why I trust you. After all, being blind means that when people try to pull the wool over my eyes, it doesn’t do a thing.”

I laugh a bit at that. After a second, I hear a polite, rather forced chuckle from Merec. I smile as if I’ve told a good joke. It’s all in the face. I keep it as open and as normal as possible, acting as if I’m talking with a good friend. It helps that I don’t have to do anything with my eyes.

Telling lies? I’m not telling lies. And I’m not dancing about with the truth either. I really *don’t* have a way of telling if someone’s lying to me. But I can make him think I do.

I’m just letting Merec and all the others do all the thinking and plotting and analysis of every word and move I make. The key is to make them think I’ve got depths, when in fact I’m about as deep as a puddle.

Mind games. From what Reynold and Ryoka said, the important people in this world like to play games with each other and read into every move anyone of power makes. My hope is that in a world of backstabbing, duplicitous schemers, they’ll never expect an honest man.

Well, semi-honest. Sort of. At least I make an effort.

Ryoka rubbed at her eyes as the discussion went on. Laken sounded *exactly* like some kind of antagonist explaining his modus operandi on a television show to her. She’d felt like cringing when he made that joke. It was an over-the-top performance, but, and she had to admit this reluctantly, it was working.

It was the way he said it that sold the acting, and that incredible presence he had. You could believe that Laken was some reclusive, eccentric nobleman helping out a village he had taken a liking to. Every eye was on him and some people were openly listening to his discussion, not bothering to hide their interest.

They were all probably wondering which royal house Laken came from, which noble family. Ryoka was wondering much the same thing, although her main question was *how*. She knew he...but the stone had...Ryoka's head was hurting already from all the suspicions bottled up in her chest.

And yet, it was all working in Laken's favor. His entire presence was a tantalizing mystery. Who was the strange man with the bag of gold and a Troll bodyguard? Ryoka could see the gears whirring in people's heads and decided to give Laken a hand.

She looked over and saw Reynold still writing furiously in the notebook, dipping his quill quickly into the small inkpot he held. She had to admire that—pens were so much easier than having to balance ink and quill and notepad with just two hands. She moved over and elbowed him, making the [Butler] jump.

“Hey. Get in there.”

He stared blankly at her.

“What?”

She nodded toward Laken and Merez as they began to discuss prices and what exactly Laken wanted.

“Do something. Anything. Just enter the conversation, alright? It doesn't matter what you say, only that you're there, saying it.”

Reynold hesitated, and then shook his head slightly.

“Miss Ryoka, my job is to escort you.”

“And take notes.”

He flushed a bit and lowered his quill.

“Well I—I can't just interfere in business like this. It's not my place.”

“Oh. Okay.”

Ryoka shrugged and walked away. After a few moments Reynold went back to writing down what was being said. He glanced over towards Ryoka and realized she was gone.

Reynold’s head turned frantically, but she wasn’t anywhere in front of him. Then he felt two hands on his back. He half turned—

And Ryoka shoved him.

She pushed Reynold forwards, sending the [Butler] stumbling closer to Laken and Meref. Reynold regained his footing and posture immediately and looked graceful while doing it, but now all eyes were on him. Ryoka looked the other way and twiddled her thumbs behind her back.

“Oops.”

I break off when I hear the scuffle of feet on the floorboards.

“Is someone there?”

I hear a man clear his throat, and then hear a familiar voice.

“Reynold, sir Laken. May I offer you my services in this matter?”

I hesitate, but only for a second. Why is he helping? No, don’t question it—just roll with the cards that are being dealt.

“I would be most grateful, thank you. Do you by any chance know how much I should be paying for forty bags of barley?”

I hear Reynold sniff delicately.

“Given the way the Merchant’s Guild does business, I would question whether the goods being sold are of acceptable quality. Master Meref, I trust these prices all reflect the condition of the wares for sale? I have heard

of weevils and Harvest Devils being found in warehouses in the city as of late.”

Merec splutters.

“Our goods are beyond repute, sir. I can have a sample brought over—”

“A sample might do, but a personal inspection of random bags at the site would not be objectionable, I trust?”

“No—no—”

“Very well then. But I also trust you are not wasting Mister Laken’s time with trivialities such as individual item counts? The Merchant’s Guild surely has a list of the cheapest and most plentiful products on hand, does it not?”

“I—will have some sent for right away.”

Ryoka grinned as she watched Merec stand and hurry off to speak urgently with some harried employees.

“Not bad, huh?”

Ivolethe, munching down on another walnut, just shrugged in reply. Ryoka shook her head.

She didn’t know what Laken’s game was, not exactly, but she knew he needed to have the [Merchants] here thinking he was a big shot. And who better to help with that bit of fiction than Reynold the [Butler]? They might not know who he was on first sight, but Ryoka would bet every gold piece she owned that the people staring at him and talking behind their hands were trying to figure out which [Lord] or [Lady] he served. Once they found out he was Magnolia’s aide...

“Ooh, looks like they’ve put it together.”

She'd never seen a ruddy face go that pale that quickly. Merec made his way back to Laken with profuse apologies and offered him a frothy fruit drink. Ryoka could have used one herself, but only Laken, Durene, and Gamel were getting the deluxe treatment. The negotiations went on, and Ryoka shifted from leg to leg until she heard adventurers being brought up.

"We have several good teams, Mister Laken. There are Gold-rank teams I could hire if you—"

"I want those two teams, Mister Merec. The Celestial Trackers and the Windfrozen Riders."

"As you say sir, but may I ask why those two...?"

Ryoka saw Laken lean back and smile mysteriously. She wondered if he'd practiced that smile or if he was just that good at acting. Or maybe that was just how he smiled?

"Here's the thing, Merec. May I call you that? I need adventurers to protect Riverfarm, but I don't want to hire people who just want coin or who will look down on the villagers. Why those two teams? Well, early today, I sent my...man out to all of the adventuring groups he could find earlier this day, begging for help. Of the ones he talked to, those two were the only ones who didn't immediately send him off or laugh at him."

Ryoka turned to stare at Gamel. Wait a second—she *remembered* seeing him doing that! He'd been approaching the teams in the plaza, begging for help!

"Clever."

Laken went on, explaining his reasoning to an enthralled Merec and the audience around him.

"When I was young, I heard a story about a [King] who did very much the same thing. Well, the story has many forms, but it's always the same. The [King] would go out, disguising himself as a peasant or ordinary man and talk with people, ask for aid, or challenge them to ascertain their worth. Only after he had gotten the measure of them would he reveal himself. For you see, people aren't genuine when they know you're rich or powerful. I want those teams, Merec. They might not be famous, but they do care."

“Of course, sir. I will have someone go over to the Adventurer’s Guild this instant—”

The young man held up a hand and Meref fell silent.

“I want to hire them not only to escort the wagons, but to guard the village for at least a month. If they won’t agree, then I will find another team. You may post more guards and adventurers if you want, but I need at least two groups to protect the village. Now, if you will tell me the price I’d be paying for that...”

Ryoka turned and moved out of the crowd of onlookers, shaking her head as she left the Merchant’s Guild.

“Amazing. How the hell did he get all that money, Ivolette?”

The faerie just stared up at Ryoka, cheeks bulging. She swallowed and didn’t answer. Ryoka scowled.

“Whatever. But at least I’ve got Reynold off my back. Well, there are probably other spies around, but I hope they like running.”

She left the building and began to jog and then run down the street. Back inside the Merchant’s Guild, Reynold stood to attention next to Laken. He knew Ryoka had gone, had seen her leave, but he couldn’t make himself abandon the conversation. Laken kept asking him questions and Reynold found himself pressing Meref hard on the young man’s behalf. He was stuck, and Reynold realized this might have been Ryoka’s plan all along.

Ryoka had intended to go to the Mage’s Guild to send the Horns of Hammerad a message, but she found herself in the Runner’s Guild first. It was just a thought. She wondered if the [Receptionist] had heard about Valceif yet.

But when she approached the counter, the young man on duty immediately asked her to wait. Confused, Ryoka found herself ushered to the side while

one of the staff on duty went to go get the [Receptionist] she'd talked to.

When the woman came walking down the stairs, Ryoka realized something was wrong. It was written all over the woman's face. The young woman felt a lurch in her stomach, though she didn't know what the problem was.

"Miss Ryoka? You were asking about the whereabouts of Valceif Godfrey?"

The [Receptionist] led Ryoka to an unused counter to talk. Ryoka nodded, keeping her voice deliberately casual.

"Yeah, I was wondering. Do you know where he is?"

"I do, Miss. I'm sorry to say that Valceif is dead. He was killed two weeks ago on a delivery."

Ryoka blinked. She rubbed at one ear and stared into the other woman's grave eyes. She opened her mouth and slowly closed it.

"How? I mean—I mean—how? How did it happen?"

"He was killed on a delivery, Miss Ryoka. A group of [Bandits] waylaid him. It wasn't an assassination or someone trying to intercept his delivery. It was simply—bad luck."

A hole had opened up in Ryoka's chest. She felt herself lurching, felt all the positive emotions drain out through a pit in her stomach and the void rush in.

"You're sure?"

"Yes, Miss Ryoka."

There was too much sympathy in the [Receptionist]'s eyes. She'd seen this before, told other Runners the same thing, Ryoka knew. She hated that. She hated...it couldn't be true.

"Bandits did it. [Bandits]? How could they get him? Valceif was—he was a *Courier*. He could outrun a horse!"

"They used magic. When they were captured, the surviving bandits said that they'd used a [Sleep] spell on the road. Apparently they took him unawares,

before he knew they were there. It's rare that a Courier doesn't have magical items to ward against such spells, but—"

Ryoka's hand had gone over her mouth when the woman mentioned the [Sleep] spell. When the [Receptionist] got to the part about magical items Ryoka threw up.

Someone got Ryoka a towel and some water to wash her mouth out with. Ryoka stared at her hands as she sat at a table.

"It was my fault. I got him killed."

There was a gasp. The [Receptionist]'s eyes flicked to the young man and other woman hovering around Ryoka. She glared at them.

"You didn't hear that. Either of you. If I hear a word out of your mouths—"

They fled. Ryoka raised her head to stare at the [Receptionist].

"Why bother hiding it? It's true. Valceif—he had—he had an amulet. A dreamcatcher that could shield him from spells. He gave it to me and I broke it. If I hadn't—"

"I understand. But you must not say that openly."

The woman stared at Ryoka.

"Why?"

"Because Valceif had friends. And family. And they might come here seeking vengeance if they hear the wrong things. Rumor would spin you as his murderer."

"I might as well be. I killed him. I did it. I let him run off without protection —"

"Listen to me."

The [Receptionist] tapped Ryoka's arm, making the younger woman look up at her. There was kindness in the other woman's gaze, but something made of steel as well.

"Valceif Godfrey was a Runner. He was a Courier—one of the best of us. He knew the risks of running without an artifact and he took it. His death was not your fault. He helped you because that is what we Runners do. The people who killed him are at fault, not you. Runners carry deliveries, but we do not bear grudges. We run and die and help each other. Valceif was a true Runner to the end."

Ryoka stared at the [Receptionist].

"You were a Runner?"

The woman's mouth turned up slightly.

"City Runner. Like you. I grew too old and slow for it. It's too dangerous and I have a child. But I know what it's like. I've lost friends too. Valceif probably thought he could outrun any mage before he bought another charm, but he made a mistake. That's always how it happens. A small mistake or bad luck."

Ryoka shuddered.

"But if—"

She paused and shook her head.

"I know. I know I couldn't have known. But if—"

"If you could have, you would. But it was just bad luck."

The two sat in silence for longer than Ryoka knew. Time lost its meaning for a while, but no one came over to bother the [Receptionist] and she ignored the queue at the desks.

After a while, the [Receptionist] thought she heard a voice. She looked at Ryoka, but saw nothing. It was a faint sound, almost indistinct. Then the woman saw a blue creature, a being of frost and ice standing by her ear. She stared at the Frost Faerie, but Ivolethe just whispered into Ryoka's ear, quietly.

Time passed. All three sat in silence, then, Ivolethe sitting on Ryoka's shoulder stared dreamily upwards. She did not weep, but there was something deep in the faerie's eyes. A hint of forever. At last, Ryoka stood up.

"I've got to go. Thank you."

The faerie darted towards her pouch and the [Receptionist] stood. She didn't comment about Ivolethe, just walked with Ryoka to the doors.

"Come back if you need to."

"I will."

Slowly, Ryoka left the Runner's Guild. All the energy she'd had before, all the excitement, was gone. She felt numb and hollow, and she remembered the feeling. She'd known it before.

Too many times. But this time Ryoka didn't give into the feeling or allow it to overtake her. That was a luxury for later. Right now she walked and then jogged down the street, feeling as though she were shot or stabbed while she moved.

The man at the desk in the Mage's Guild was only too happy to show Ryoka the many messages left for her. In truth, they were all short slips of paper, [Message] spells being far too expensive for long missives, but there were a lot of them.

Ryoka stood at the counter, aware of the man's eyes on her as she flipped through message after message. Quite a few were from Krshia, asking when she would come back.

There is unrest. You must return soon. Do you have what is needed?

Ryoka remembered the book full of spells in her bag of holding. Another promise, long delayed. She shook her head and read the next piece of parchment.

This one was from Ceria.

...hope you can reply soon. Let us know. We hope all is well.

They must have been worried without a response for days. Ryoka felt something else stab into her heart, but it was already bleeding so it hurt only a bit.

The next message was from Pisces and more direct.

What's taking so long?

Just that. Ryoka sighed and took the next bit of parchment out. She read it and froze. It was from Lyonette.

Come back. Mrsha misses you.

The void in Ryoka's heart didn't shrink, but now she could feel it hurting. She thought of Mrsha. How long had it been since she'd seen her? She'd just run off, looking for Erin—but Erin had come back and Ryoka hadn't.

"I have to go back."

The bored man at the desk looked up, but Ryoka's eyes were on the pieces of paper. She pulled a lengthy one out from Erin and almost smiled at it.

"Excuse me."

"Yes, Miss? How can I help you?"

The man covered a sigh as Ryoka pulled out a bag of coins.

"I need to send a message to all these people in Liscor. Can you post an open response or something?"

"Certainly. What would you like to send?"

The man had a silver-tipped quill ready. He paused over a piece of parchment as Ryoka closed her eyes.

"Tell them I'm sorry. And I'll be home soon."

The man paused, and coughed.

"Do you mean for me to write 'tell them I'm sorry' or—"

Ryoka glared at him.

“No. Write ‘I’m sorry. I will return home soon’. That’s the general response. Now—I have specific messages I want sent to Erin Solstice, Krshia Silverfang, Ceria Springwalker, and...one for Mrsha, to be delivered to any of the people I just mentioned.”

The Mage’s Guild hired only those who could write as fast as other people talked. The man neatly wrote down each of the recipients as Ryoka mentioned them. Ryoka stared at his quill blurring over the parchment.

“Oh, and I want the messages sent right now. Yes, I’ll pay extra.”

The man coughed as Ryoka slapped down coins on the counter.

“Very well. May I have the first message, please?”

“Right. This one’s for Ceria.”

Ryoka closed her eyes and thought. Then she began speaking.

“This is Ryoka. I have had the items analyzed. Contents are as follows: magical sword, strong enchantment. Second sword: damaged beyond repair. Useless. Dagger—flame enchantment. Useful. Buckler: damaged but can be repaired. May have to sell one item to repair the rest...”

Her voice was low, but clear and precise. Ryoka dictated her message for Ceria, and then Krshia, and then left a message for Mrsha before pondering how to reply to Erin’s question. She thought about what she needed to get done in the city before she left, what she could say to Laken, and what to do about the magical items that Hedault was keeping for her.

It was hard, very hard. Every two seconds Ryoka remembered a grinning face, and a man who ran past her. She remembered his back, and the burning air in her lungs as she tried to keep up.

Just for a moment. It had just been a few days, but she had liked him. Ryoka closed her eyes as her breath caught in her chest, and the man at the desk looked up expectantly. But Valceif was dead. She’d mourn him later. Right now, she had a job to do. She had people counting on her, and Ryoka couldn’t let them down as well.

Slowly, painfully, Ryoka got back to work.

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The word that travelled north was brief, but noteworthy. Amid the surge and ebb of tensions among the city-states and local aristocracy, it stood out.

Around the city of Liscor that marked the sole safe passage between the northern and southern parts of Izril, news was seldom good. The Goblin Lord was only the most recent of bad tidings; the Human cities were always facing some minor crisis. After all, they bordered not only the ill-tempered Drake lands, but the High Passes, from which bands of monsters occasionally emerged to wreak havoc.

In addition, the city-states that far south were far newer and less well-developed than their northern counterparts. Celum was a far cry from a northern city like Rectes, let alone a major hub like Invrisil.

But the whisper that came north by mage [Message] was hopeful. It was a simple line that made those in the know sit up:

Esthelm has risen.

Esthelm has returned.

Esthelm is not dead.

The city lives. The people rebuild the walls, and pledge to stay and fight rather than give way to the Goblin Lord's armies. It was a small miracle, but what was far more miraculous was hearing where this sudden surge of life and hope had come from.

Esthelm had received aid...from Liscor of all places! No, not just Liscor—the *Antinium* of all species had come to help them. And somehow, Celum had sent a convoy down the roads without it falling prey to the Goblin armies.

Such boldness from the southern cities and generosity from the Antinium and Drakes was unprecedented. But with this, Esthelm might well recover and survive another Goblin assault and the remaining winter.

For a few seconds, hope blossomed in the cold. But just as quickly as it had been heard, the news of Esthelm would pass from the minds of all but a few listeners. Oh, some [Merchants] would mark down Esthelm as a prime target for business in the future if it survived, and a bold [Trader] might calculate the odds of making it to the city alive with a caravan, but no one else would pay attention to such news.

Almost no one. In fact, only two individuals of note paid attention to the news of Esthelm, despite their urgent business. The most powerful [Lady] on the continent listened to the news of the city's revival and wondered, and the most infamous [Lord] frowned and adjusted his plans slightly to account for this discrepancy.

And then they too returned to business. Esthelm was put out of mind and the world continued to move onwards. Just for a moment though, it had shone brightly for all to see. For a moment, the world had stopped and stared at the small spark glowing there.

And who had lit the spark? It was a conflagration of many hands and claws it was true, but the young woman from which it had all started was a young [Innkeeper]. She dozed lightly as a wagon trundled down the road back to Liscor just before dawn. It was far too early for such a trip she felt, but the roads were clear, and Termin had wanted to go now.

“After all, that second army of Goblins has been raiding and burnt down a town not fifty miles north of here. If I'm moving my wagon, it's with a convoy or clear roads or not at all.”

Thus, he'd persuaded the reluctant Erin to ride back with him to Liscor, escorted by the Horns of Hammerad as before. They lay asleep in the back of the wagon, exhausted from a day of work.

More traffic would soon flow south to Liscor. The majority of wagons would head back, as would the Gold-rank adventurers, Zel Shivertail, and a good portion of the Antinium who'd come north.

Only a day had passed since Esthelm had received aid. That was too short a time to effect that much change, although the Antinium had managed to repair a good deal of the walls themselves. But the convoy had done its job, and staying longer would do no good. Extra hands to help meant extra

mouths to feed, and the food and supplies that had been brought would go to waste that way.

So the adventurers who had been hired would stay, the extra [Guardsmen], [Hunters], [Healers], and so on would lend their expertise, and a group of Antinium Workers and Soldiers under Anand's supervision would stay to complete construction work. Everyone else would leave.

That suited Erin just fine. She woke up a bit as the cold air blew into her face. But after adjusting her head so she was sheltered by the wagon's sides, she dozed off.

Woke up again. This time Erin saw Liscor in the distance. She blinked around blearily and decided a few more minutes wouldn't hurt...

"Miss Erin? We're here."

A hand shook Erin gently. She groaned and then opened her eyes.

The wagon was parked right next to the hill the inn stood on. Erin looked at Termin, and realized he'd stopped here for her.

"Oh, thanks, Termin!"

He smiled at her, and dipped his head slightly.

"My pleasure."

There was much more to say, but it was too early. Erin got up and woke up the other Horns of Hammerad by yanking the blankets off them. They swore at her—Ceria nearly hit Erin with her skeletal hand before she opened her eyes. But they did get up.

It was customary to tip drivers, even if they had been paid. Erin fished around for a coin but Termin waved her away.

"Treat me to a meal tonight, miss. You'll be open? Then I'll be there."

He gently flapped the reins and Erma and Fox began to plod off.

"Bastard. It's not a minute's travel up the hill."

Pisces glared at the wagon as it rolled through the snow. Erin glared blearily at him, shivering already despite the blanket she'd draped around her shoulders for extra protection.

"That's a lot of work for his horses. We can walk. Come on."

Silently, the adventurers trudged up the hill after Erin. She pushed open the door to her inn and they practically fell down the steps to the basement. Erin paused only to make sure they had enough blankets. Everyone but Ksmvr was already back asleep.

Silently, Erin wandered over to the fireplace and added a few logs that had been piled up next to it. The glowing embers set fire to the wood as she blew carefully at it.

The ash made her cough. Erin took a few steps back and stared as the temperature in the common room began to rise. She glanced towards the window.

It was still night. But there was light there, too. It would be dawn soon.

If she were back home, Erin would have been dead asleep—or going to sleep if she'd pulled another all-nighter playing chess online or studying games. She would have never contemplated anything remotely resembling hard work at this hour, and probably would have slept in till one.

"Huh. I guess I'm a morning person now."

Erin smiled, and bowed her head as she shivered and sat at an empty table in her inn. She closed her eyes, but that was a mistake.

Yes, if she were back home, she'd be lying in bed with her laptop, covered with blankets as the snow fell outside. Maybe she would be thinking about getting a part-time job, or what college would be like next year. She'd be studying chess or chatting online with a friend and—

Memory.

It hurt. Erin bit her lip, so hard she nearly punctured skin. She stood up and sighed. Swaying on her feet, Erin frowned. She was still waking up.

"...not now. But it's Christmas time. Time...?"

The mumbling attracted attention. Erin heard the creak of someone descending the stairs and saw Lyonette rubbing her eyes as she walked down. The young woman froze when she saw Erin standing in the center of the room, but then she relaxed.

“Oh. I thought—”

Erin nodded at her. Lyonette silently stumbled down the steps. Both girls stood in the room, staring at each other. Without saying anything, a consensus was reached that it was far too early for anything resembling conversation.

Erin sat back down. Then she stood up with a groan and went into the kitchen to prepare food for the masses. Lyonette went outside with a bucket for water.

Some things were easiest to do on autopilot. Erin mechanically made crepes in a batter and fried them up. She was munching on a buttery crepe before she properly woke up. The hot food was burning her hands, but it was food so she didn't care.

The sun was coming up. Now Erin could think, she wandered back into the common room, leaving a heap of crepes in a bowl covered with a towel. They could always be reheated, and she had too much work to do to stay in the kitchen.

“Time to get to work.”

“Huh?”

Lyonette paused mid-bite, a piece of crepe halfway towards her mouth. She blinked blearily at Erin. The young woman waved at her [Barmaid].

“I said I'm going to work. A lot. Today's going to be busy, Lyon. I think you'll have to stay in the inn most of the time, but I'll be running around like a chicken with its head cut off.”

The young woman sitting at the table nodded. She paused, frowned, and woke up a bit more. Then she thought about what Erin had said.

“Do they actually do that?”

“What?”

“Chickens. Do they really run around when you...I mean, if you...”

Lyonette gulped. Erin paused.

“Maybe? I dunno, I’ve never actually tried it. It’s just what people say where I come from.”

“Oh.”

The two girls stared at each other. After a second, Erin coughed.

“We don’t do that *all* the time. It’s just...”

“No, I understand.”

“Right. Well then...I’m off to the city!”

Awkwardly, Erin edged out the door. She came back in to grab a money pouch and fill it with coins. She was feeling the rush of sugar and adrenaline now. She put a smile on her face and fixed it there.

“Do we need anything, Lyon? I mean, Lyonette?”

“Um. Lyon’s fine I guess. We need some more flour, a few tomatoes if you want to make that ‘cats-up’ stuff, and some salt. I think we’ve got enough for tonight.”

“Alright, got it! Oh, and one more thing—”

Erin poked her head back through the door. Lyonette looked at her expectantly.

“Christmas is coming.”

“What’s that?”

“It’s a holiday! Everyone’s going to get presents and have fun, so...think of some gifts for people, okay? You’ll have to get presents for uh, two other people. It can be food, something small or fun or anything like that. Just think of something nice to give someone else.”

“Okay?”

“Thanks! I’ll explain the rest later!”

It was just a smile, but Erin wore it like a shield. Smiling helped. Smiling made you think the day might not be horrible after all. Not that she thought today *would* be horrible, but she had a lot to do, and she was going to do it cheerful or she’d kill herself.

Or someone. Like the sleepy guardsman at the gate. The Drake on duty just stared at Erin as she stood outside the closed gates. After five minutes he managed to get them open enough for her to slip through.

“I have so much to do!”

Erin grouched to herself as she stomped across the streets of Liscor, trying not to slip on the snow-covered paving stones. There was practically no one up yet, but she found Market Street at least partially occupied. While pedestrians had yet to hit the streets, the shopkeepers were setting up, miserably trying to stay warm while they opened their stalls.

Erin found one familiar Gnoll grumbling to herself as she dusted snow off of her counter with a paw. Krshia Silverfang turned before Erin could call out to her. The Gnoll sniffed and smiled as Erin approached her small stall.

“Krshia!”

The young woman beamed at her. The Gnoll smiled and beckoned Erin closer. They huddled beneath her stall’s flimsy walls from the wind while they chatted.

“Erin Solstice. It has been far, far too long since we have spoken properly, yes?”

“Yes! How are you doing, Krshia? I know we talked a bit at the party, but there’s so much that has happened!”

“Indeed. We must catch up. But first—have you business with me?”

“I do! Here—oh wait, I don’t have a list. But I know what I need.”

“Hmm. Let me fetch a piece of parchment and charcoal, yes?”

Erin chatted with Krshia as the Gnoll wrote down her shopping list and told her it would be delivered to her inn by the end of the day. Erin put a few coins on the table and got three bronze coins in change. Then she took a deep breath and got to the real reason she’d sought Krshia out so early.

“Krshia, I know Lyonette’s um...well, I know she did a lot of things while I was gone.”

“That is so. Hrm. You say you have done much in Celum while you were away, yes? Well, Lyonette has...also done much here.”

Erin peeked up at the tall Gnoll’s face. Krshia’s expression was hard to read, but her ears weren’t flat. That was a good sign.

“I know you didn’t want her back in the city. But she came in, didn’t she?”

Krshia paused, and her ears did *twitch* then. But her voice remained level and calm. Or seemingly calm.

“She was allowed back in the city by Zel Shivertail, no? What is a Gnoll’s pride before the famous hero of the Antinium Wars? We will do nothing to her, not when the Council is against us.”

“I’m sorry. But she came back to—”

“Save the child Mrsha. I know. It makes it better, no?”

“No. Well, yes. Maybe. But she only did it because of that. She won’t come back otherwise. And I had a chat with her, and...well, she’s sorry and she’ll try to make amends.”

“So I have seen. But her debt is large, Erin.”

“I know. I just wanted to say that she’s going to try and stay out of the city unless it’s an emergency. And a bit of the money she gets paid—once I actually pay her—will go to you for your shop. It’s not much, but it’s what she can do. What I can do.”

Krshia blinked down at Erin. She didn’t immediately reply. Erin shivered.

“I know it’s not enough. But she’s trying, okay?”

“Hrm. I understand.”

Krshia shook her head. She looked tired as she flicked a bit of snow that had dared to land on her counter off onto the ground.

“That Human child is odd. Odd, but I see her trying. It is not enough, but it will do. Let us not talk of such things, Erin. You have just returned—again. Let us talk of good matters, or as much good as there is on such cold days.”

“Okay.”

Erin smiled at Krshia and saw the Gnoll bare her canines in response. After a second, Erin frowned.

“Krshia, what’s the Council? That’s the group that rules Liscor, right? Who are they? I’ve never seen them.”

The Gnoll shrugged. She glanced hopefully up and down the street, but Erin was her only customer. A few Drakes were starting on one end of the street, but it would be several minutes before they got to her.

“The Council is made up of important people in the city. It is a Drake thing. The foremost people sit on it and decide what must be done from time to time.”

“Really, who are they?”

Another shrug. Krshia frowned a bit as she replied, which made Erin think that Gnolls didn’t get much of a place on the Council.

“The head of the Adventurer’s Guild, the foremost [Mage], usually head of the Mage’s Guild...hrm, the Captain of the Watch, Zevara, the head of the Merchant’s Guild...Olesm...”

“*Olesm!*?”

“He is chief [Tactician] in the city. He must advise on matters that may be military. He has a voice.”

“Wow. I had no idea he was actually that important!”

“Well, it is a civilian council. While the army is away they leave such people in charge. You know Liscor’s army is a mercenary one? They are a power unto their own, but they rarely return to the city.”

“Huh.”

Erin thought about that for a second. Then she stared at Krshia. The Gnoll wasn’t shivering, but she looked miserable, standing in her small stall waiting for customers as the snow fell down again.

Miserable. Perhaps it was her stall. It was too small. Erin remembered how it had looked before, how many wares Krshia had had on display. Now...

“I’m sorry about your shop. Did I say that before? I’m really sorry about it. I know it was hard—and I’d like to help if I can.”

Krshia blinked at Erin and shook her head.

“You say it as if it was your fault. It is not.”

“But I need to say it. I hired Lyonette, and I know you were upset. It must be so hard—if I can do anything, I will. That’s what friends are for.”

The [Shopkeeper] just shook her head.

“I must have new wares to sell, and that costs money. To sell I must buy, and I have less coin than I did. My friends in the city and those from my tribe aid me. They lend me coin and I buy and sell with that. It is enough. It is not as if you can give me more business—unless there is something like those hamburgers I may sell?”

She looked inquiringly at Erin, but without any real hope. Erin hesitated, and then smiled.

“I do have some ideas. Maybe not things I can make, but—I’ll try.”

“It is all I ask, yes? But where does this spirit come from?”

“I did a lot of thinking. Well, mostly on the wagon ride to Esthelm and back. I think I can help, and not just by giving you a bunch of coin or anything. I just—I want to make sure my friends are doing okay. Which reminds me, where’s Brunkr? I heard he was sick from Klbkch!”

Krshia paused. She had been smiling a bit at Erin. Now the smile vanished into the cold.

“My nephew? He is poor. He rests in my home, Erin. He will...be better after he gains the courage to do what must be done, I think.”

“What’s that?”

Krshia looked uncomfortable. She shook her head and glanced around the street.

“Better if you see for yourself. I would let him explain or you see, but not say it. Hrr. Perhaps there is time before more come to shop. Would you like to see?”

Erin hesitated. Krshia was clearly upset. If she wasn’t saying...

“Sure.”

It was a quick walk to Krshia’s apartment. Erin opened the door and recognized the cozy home. Nothing much had changed since her last visit, save for what looked like a heap of rugs on Krshia’s couch. Then someone groaned and the pile of rugs turned into Brunkr, wrapped up in blankets as he lay in Krshia’s home.

“Brunkr? I have come back, yes? And brought someone to visit.”

Krshia spoke quietly to Brunkr. He made no reply. He was lying with the blanket wrapped around his huge frame. Something stank horribly. Erin made a face and suppressed the urge to gag. She peered at Brunkr, but couldn’t see anything, cocooned as he was.

“What’s wrong with him?”

“Go away, Human.”

Brunkr’s voice was muffled but distinct. She saw him roll and then two dark brown eyes glared malevolently at her.

“Leave me, Erin Solstice. And take your cursed doombringer far away from me. Leave her yourself unless you wish to end up as I do.”

Doombringer? Erin frowned and then realized he meant Mrsha. Krshia frowned at Brunkr.

“Nephew! Be silent. Do not blame bad luck on the Mrsha child.”

Brunkr ignored his aunt. He sat up with an effort, groaning as his legs slowly unfolded and he shifted the blanket. The smell grew worse. It was the smell of...Erin’s stomach roiled and the crepes threatened to come up. The Gnoll warrior was breathing heavily and sweat was staining his fur as he stared at Krshia.

“Is it time to cut it off? Is that why you have come?”

“Cut? Cut what off?”

Erin blinked at Brunkr. He stared incredulously at her, and then snarled. He tore off the blanket from his frame and thrust his right hand at her.

Both Human and Gnoll recoiled. Erin saw yellow dripping pus, oozing around red broken skin covered in horribly stained fur—in an instant she realized where the smell was coming from. The blanket Brunkr had tossed to the floor was also covered in dried yellow gunk.

It was horrible. And disgusting. Erin swallowed hard and forced her stomach to stay still.

“What’s that? How did you...?”

“Your cursed one *bit* me.”

Brunkr snarled at Erin. He cradled his hand, unable to touch it as more yellow pus dripped slowly out of the infected injury on his arm. Erin couldn’t look away from the horrible sight.

Whatever Mrsha had done, and Erin vaguely recalled her biting Brunkr only a bit, that small injury had turned into a full-scale infection that had taken over a good portion of Brunkr’s forearm. It was horrible, and clearly not healing.

“That’s bad.”

Both Brunkr and Krshia stared at Erin. She gulped again.

“That’s real bad. Um, Brunkr. Mrsha did this? Have you—I mean, I’m sorry, but she didn’t mean to do that. Have you had that looked at by a [Healer]? Or gotten a healing potion or something? If you need to, I can pay for—”

The male Gnoll made a sound of fury and turned away violently. Krshia pulled at Erin’s arm and whispered to her as the two stood by the door.

“It is not something curable with a healing potion, and the [Healers] cannot fix such an injury, Erin. Not ones from Liscor—and not ones from Celum, I fear. It is too far infected now. Only magic might save it, and few know healing spells for this.”

“Oh. Oh no.”

Erin didn’t know what to say. She understood the problem. Maybe Brunkr would be okay in her world, but here a healing potion and [Healer] were the only types of medicine available. And neither one was specialized in fighting diseases or infections.

“It is my doom, brought upon me. It will fall on the rest of you as well.”

Brunkr stood in a corner, holding his arm, not looking at the other two. He had heard every word they had said with his acute hearing.

His arm. It was a ghastly sight, but Erin couldn’t look away for some reason. She kept waiting for Brunkr to turn so she could stare at it again.

Her right hand twinged. Erin stared down at it, and remembered a similar sight. She looked at Krshia questioningly.

“Back when my hand was all cut up Klbkch gave me a healing potion. It worked, even though it was sort of infected. Are you sure a healing potion—a good one—wouldn’t...?”

Krshia shook her head instantly.

“Light infections, perhaps. The body will fight it off in the end, yes? So a healing potion makes it faster. But deep rot such as this...no. It will only speed up the infection.”

“So what can you do?”

Krshia didn't reply. But she stared at Brunkr and Erin saw the Gnoll's entire body tense up. Erin went pale.

"No. Really?"

"He must—"

"No! Not yet!"

Brunkr's voice was full of anguish. He bent over his hand, making a sound that was more animal than word. Erin saw Krshia staring at her younger nephew with deep sorrow—but also something cold in her gaze.

"It must be soon, nephew. Erin, even she can see your hand is gone, yes?"

"No!"

"No!"

The echo came from Erin's mouth. Both Gnolls stared at her, Brunkr turning his head to look. Erin was shaking her head.

"No, Erin Solstice? But you see his hand. It must go or the rot will consume him as well."

"No, it's—maybe something can be done. Krshia, let me—I think something can be done."

"Truly?"

"Impossible!"

Brunkr snapped at Erin, showing his teeth. Erin felt her heart beating faster, but not from fear. She stared at Brunkr's hand and thought of doctors, hospitals. She had no idea—only a vague recollection of taking tablets and getting shots, but maybe...

"Let me try to help, okay? I think I have an idea. I'll come back—"

"Do not lie to me, Human."

Brunkr glared at Erin, seemingly more infuriated by her offer to help than his aunt's words. Erin held her ground as he stumbled towards her. Brunkr's voice was slurred by pain and grief, but he was still a warrior of a Gnoll

tribe. He towered over her as he glared and Erin saw Krshia staring warily at her nephew.

“Humans—hrr. I hear Humans say try and give up in an instant. What can you do that my tribe—my aunt cannot? Can you save my hand? Tell me. If you lie, I will know.”

“I can try.”

Erin looked Brunkr in the eye. He stared at her. The anger was replaced by dull resignation in an instant.

“You will fail, and say you did all you could. Your words are empty.”

“I don’t give up that easily. Here.”

Erin stepped past Brunkr, to a pile of rags that smelled horrible. She found a bucket of water and washed the rags briskly as Krshia guided Brunkr back to the couch. Erin wrung the cloth and pressed it on Brunkr’s head. The Gnoll groaned and lay back. Erin turned to Krshia and silently the two females left her apartment.

“If you can help, I will give all to save his hand. But is it possible?”

“I don’t know. I don’t know, Krshia, but I know who I can ask.”

“Who?”

“Ryoka.”

That was all they said on the matter. Back at Krshia’s stall, Erin stood in front of it, feeling heavier than she had when she’d just woken up. She couldn’t get the image of Brunkr’s infected hand out of her head.

Krshia seemed equally weighed down, despite Erin’s assurances. She looked so *tired*. It hurt Erin’s heart. The girl cast around for something, anything that could make the Gnoll feel better, and then remembered one of the things she had decided to do. She put a smile on her face and made it stick by sheer force of will.

Lighthearted tone. Erin took a breath and did her best.

“I know Brunkr’s in bad shape, but can I tell you about something that’s going to happen a few days from now, Krshia?”

“Hm? What is this thing, Erin Solstice?”

Krshia eyed Erin as the girl tried to summon the powers of the holiday spirit. She spread her arms.

“Christmas! I know you don’t know what that is, but listen. Back where I come from...back from my world, we have a tradition. Every year, in the winter, just before the new year starts, we celebrate Christmas.”

“Hrm. The shortest day of the year, the winter solstice is yet a few days away. Before this is Christmas, you say? What happens on this day?”

“We celebrate. We give each other presents, eat lots of food—oh, and Santa Claus comes to give things to everyone!”

The Gnoll just stared at Erin. The girl tried to explain. She got most of the points across, although Krshia still didn’t understand why a fat man would run around with presents and coal to give to everyone. But the Gnoll *was* smiling when Erin had finished.

“So you intend to celebrate this—this day of giving soon?”

“Yes! Tomorrow, maybe? Or the day after? I know there’s not a lot of time to get gifts, but we can all try, right? But we have to do it *before* the new year’s. That’s very important. So...do you want to join in? I’m going to have everyone give gifts to two people so everyone gets presents. We’ll have a huge party at my inn and everything!”

Erin held her breath as Krshia thought about the idea. The Gnoll rubbed her face with a furry paw, and then smiled again.

“Christmas. Yes, it could be a nice thing to do. And I must give gifts to two others? Whom? Or will it be a surprise?”

Erin hesitated.

“I think that could get weird. I’ll come up with a list and tell everyone who their people are. I’ll uh, also make sure you don’t get Lyonette and she

doesn't get you. I guess I should keep Klbkch and Zel from being Secret Santas too."

"Hrm. That may be wise, yes."

Krshia bared her teeth in a smile. Erin smiled back.

"Okay. I've got to go. But I'll be back. And—I'll be back."

"I know. Go safely, Erin. And have a merry...Christmas, yes?"

"Yeah!"

The girl waved and hurried off down the street. Krshia watched her go, and then sighed. The thought of her nephew was like a burden on her, a heavy stone. But somehow, she thought of it differently now. She managed to smile, and perhaps it was that which attracted a middle-aged Drake across the street to Krshia's stall.

The Gnoll smiled wider, and began to talk with the Drake. Perhaps she was only there for a chat, but Krshia thought she could smell an opportunity here.

"Hello, Tesha. Have you heard of an interesting Human tradition? No? It is called 'Christmas'. I tell you because it is coming soon, and you may wish to buy presents if you wish to partake. You see, on Christmas..."

So much to do, and so little time. Erin was trying to figure out which street to go down when she saw a familiar face and scales in the crowd. She called out at once.

"Olesm!"

"Erin? I was just going to see if you were back!"

The Drake beamed at her. They stopped in the middle of the street, the vapor trails of their conversation floating upwards as they talked and

shivered.

“How are you, Olesm? We barely talked before—Lyonette says you were a huge help to her while I was gone. Thank you so much!”

“Aw, it was nothing—well, actually, it was sort of hard.”

Olesm frowned as he nudged Erin. They stood aside to let a grumpy Drake wearing armor and a group of other armed Drakes stomp by. The Drake wearing the most impressive regalia snorted as he saw Erin talking with Olesm.

“Humans.”

He passed by and Olesm shook his head.

“Sorry—what was I saying? Oh yeah, I was happy to help Lyonette. But it’s a good thing she managed to patch things up with the Gnolls so they’d deliver to her. My arms nearly fell off trying to haul all the food she wanted up to the inn every day! I don’t know how you do it!”

“You get strong. See?”

Erin tried to flex her arm to show Olesm, but all the clothes on her body made that futile. Olesm smiled and then fidgeted.

“I don’t suppose you’re free right now, Erin? I’d love to chat with you—I mean, there’s so much I’ve been meaning to show you, and I’d love to play a game if…”

Erin sighed and Olesm’s face fell.

“I’m sorry, Olesm. But I’m so busy! I have to go to the Mage’s Guild after this, and then…”

“I completely understand. I’ll ask again later.”

Olesm raised his claws and made to back away. Erin felt a pang as she saw how disappointed he was—and how hard he was trying to hide that fact.

“Why don’t you come to the inn after lunch? I’ll definitely have time to talk then. We can play a few games of chess and—oh, I can show you how to play Go!”

The blue-scaled Drake paused. His tail began to wag hopefully in the snow.

“Really? You mean it? I won’t be interrupting?”

“I’ll make time. It’s a promise, okay? After lunch. You can make it, right?”

“I’ll be there! No problem! Let me just—I’ll have to get my notes, and a bottle of fresh ink—and I can show you all the letters I’ve received. I’ll be there! At your inn, right? Definitely!”

Erin smiled as Olesm rushed off, practically jumping for joy. Then she frowned.

“After lunch? Gotta go faster, then.”

She stomped down the street, searching for the Mage’s Guild. In truth, Erin had never been there, but it wasn’t hard to find the place.

There wasn’t a line this early in the day, and the Drake at the counter was clearly bored. He didn’t seem any happier to have to serve anyone, but Erin gave him her best smile anyways.

“Hi there, you do messages by spell, right? Can I send a message to... Invril? How much would that cost, actually?”

The Drake stared at Erin, and grudgingly pointed his claw to a large sign with prices listed right above his head. Erin turned red and stared at them.

“Payment is up front. We don’t send packages by magic either; you’ll need to go to a Walled City or another city for that.”

The Drake’s voice was testy. Erin nodded a few times.

“Got it...not too pricy, huh. Okay, I think I’d like to send a message to my friend! Can I send it now, or do I have to wait?”

The Drake pointed to the sign again.

“There’s a fee for quick deliveries. Just tell me your friend’s name and I’ll have it addressed to her.”

Erin gave him Ryoka’s name, spelling it out for him as he frowned over the odd spelling, grumbling about Human names. Her message was simple, and

was written verbatim.

“Hey Ryoka, this is Erin! I need help! I just spoke with Krshia—you know she’s got a nephew, Brunkr, right? Well, he’s got an infected hand and I was wondering—okay. Wow. That much? Um, Ryoka, lots of money to send this, so...how to heal infected hand? Also, when are you coming back? Christmas is soon. Come back soon!”

After that, Erin had to pay and wait for the [Clerk] to take the letter upstairs to the [Mage] on duty. She got a small receipt and her change—she was paying in gold coins since the Gold-rank adventurers didn’t seem to have smaller denominations.

Erin wondered if Ryoka would get the message. She was about to hurry back to her inn when the Drake at the desk suddenly called out after her.

“Miss? Miss Human!”

She came back to the counter. He was frowning at something that had just shot down a small tube from upstairs. It was a slip of parchment, folded up. He showed it to Erin.

“A reply just came back. It seems your friend has already received your message. She is at the Mage’s Guild in Invril this moment.”

“*What?*”

Erin stared at the [Clerk.]

“That’s a weird coincidence.”

He didn’t look as astounded as Erin felt.

“It happens. Normally we would take in her message with the rest as it comes in, but she paid to send a reply back fast.”

“Oh. Well then...can you tell Ryoka I’m here? Or do I have to send another message?”

The Drake paused. He looked reluctant to be awake, and more reluctant to have to speak with an uninformed customer, but Erin’s smile wore him down and he decided to be helpful.

“Why don’t I send a message requesting a two-way communication between you two?”

“Wow. You can do that? Thank you! But will it cost a lot?”

The Drake coughed, looking around the empty building.

“If you were paying for a mage to be on standby, yes. But it’s clear around here and I know Invril has mages to spare...we’ll deliver all your messages sent immediately for an upfront fee, and every message sent afterwards. It’s not cheap, but if you have the gold to spend you can get a reply right away.”

“In that case, let’s have a chat!”

Erin plonked gold coins on the counter and the Drake sighed only slightly before scribbling down on a bit of parchment. He had to talk to the [Mage] on duty—and then send a message to Invril to Ryoka and the people there. But in the end Erin found herself dictating responses to him and waiting for a response as Ryoka got messages back on her end and replied.

It was a thousand, no, ten thousand times worse than the most disjointed Skype call. Erin had to dictate a message to the [Clerk] and then wait for as many as ten minutes for a reply. She passed that time chatting with him and introducing the idea of Christmas to his world, but it was still arduous.

When all was transcribed and done, the conversation the [Clerk] had written down for Erin read like a chat session, albeit one marked down with ink on parchment.

[Erin] – Hi Ryoka! This is Erin! Are you okay? How are things? I’m in Liscor right now! The Horns of Hammerad brought me back! How’s Magnolia doing? What’s up?

[Ryoka] – Don’t waste money. What’s this about infection? Describe. How bad; symptoms. Any complications on return?

[Erin] – Sorry. No bad things! Met Teriarch—mean! Brunkr has tons of pus—yellow and stinky! Mrsha bit, now whole arm is bad! Krshia says choppy-chop. I say no! How to fix?

[Ryoka] – Will talk T later. Brunkr needs antibiotics. Can't heal with time; penicillin is best bet. Can tell how to make, but too slow. Chop might be only way, but must make sure new wound does not spread. Let me think. Wait for response.

The message looked like Ryoka had had to spell out penicillin letter by letter for the poor [Clerk] on duty. Erin had to wait eight minutes for the next response.

[Ryoka] – P recipe: needs to let mold grow. If you know origin—poultice. Must grow greenish-blue mold on orange or bread. But must isolate. Not all molds are P obviously. Very difficult; hire O to do it. In meantime, best bet is disinfection and honey.

[Erin] – Honey? Really?

[Ryoka] – Yes. Honey can have antibiotic if natural. Clean wound thoroughly. Use hot, salt water. Clean area, apply clean dressing. Think germs. Change dressings regularly. Honey must be applied after cleaning.

[Erin] – Got it. Will try! And...new thought! What about matches?

[Ryoka] – Matches? Why?

[Erin] – Christmas! It's Christmas soon! You must come back with presents! We will have party! Can you take carriage back? Tell Reynold he is invited too!

[Ryoka] – Will try. Much to do here. Matches—talk O. Needs P from Periodic Table for striking box. Powdered glass, P...striker. Combine with sulfur and other things for match head. Other ingredients can figure out. Understand?

[Erin] – Sort of. I know P from table!

[Ryoka] – Red P. Not sure if discovered. See if O knows. May be substitute. For striking box, understand? Can use sandpaper maybe instead.

[Erin] – Got it! When coming back?

[Ryoka] – Unsure.

[Erin] – Come, please! Party is in two days! Come for Christmas! Tell Magnolia she is Scrooge! Ressa is cool.

[Ryoka] – Will try. Leaving now.

Possibly there had never been such a confusing conversation for any [Clerk] to record. Both girls didn't bother with grammar when delivering their messages and indeed, the only reason the words were spelled correctly was that the [Mages] couldn't handle texting slang. Erin left the Drake at the desk with her money pouch lighter, but newfound hope in her heart. She strode out of the guild, muttering to herself and thinking fast.

“Penicillin, matches, and honey. I can get Lyonette to help with that, but Ryoka sure knows a lot. If she knows how matches work...hm...I should have asked about...wait, that gives me a great idea!”

Erin patted at her pockets, looking for something to write with, and then marched back inside the Mage's Guild to borrow the [Clerk]'s quill for a second. She ended up going back to Krshia to buy an inkpot and ink.

It was hard to scribble on parchment and walk, and in the end Erin had to wait until she got back to the inn to write on the back of the piece of parchment. She'd already tripped once and stained quite a lot of snow black.

When Erin was hiking up towards her inn, she noticed a good deal more activity going on. That was confirmed by a ball of white fur that shot out the door as she got close.

“Hey Mrsha! I'm back! Whoops, don't make me spill this on your fur. Let me just write this down...bicycle...there!”

Erin laughed, tried to fend off Mrsha, and get inside all at once. When she finally made it in, she saw that the Horns of Hammerad were up.

“Hey guys! Are the others not back yet?”

“They're still on the road. But they should be back by tonight.”

Yvlon blinked at Erin, still looking tired. It was still early morning Erin realized. Everyone was having breakfast as Lyonette heated up Erin's crepes.

Putting Mrsha on a table, Erin grabbed a crepe and devoured it with her gloves still on. Then she turned to Ceria.

"I just had a chat with Ryoka."

"*You did?*"

All of the Horns of Hammerad sat up. Erin nodded as she gulped from a glass of water Mrsha rushed over to her. It was half-empty from being spilled as the Gnoll ran with it, but Erin appreciated the effort.

"I was talking with her! She was in Invril, and she sent me [Messages]! She'll be back soon—in time for Christmas, I hope! She says she's got messages for you too, Ceria! Apparently she identified all those items you found!"

"*She did?*"

The Horns of Hammerad were out of the door like a shot. Pisces only stopped long enough to grab as much food as he could hold; Yvlon, Ceria, and Ksmvr didn't even wait to do that. Bemused, Erin stood aside and watched them storming down the hill, slipping and sliding in the snow. She could hear Ksmvr shouting after them as he brought up the rear.

"What is Christmas? Pisces, please ex—"

"Hey, Pisces moves really fast with that [Flash Step] spell. He can eat *and* outrun Ceria! Wish I could do that."

Erin stared at the figures rushing towards Liscor. She shook her head and then turned. Mrsha and Lyonette were staring over the remains of the half-eaten breakfast. Erin smiled at both and then clapped her hands.

"Lyonette!"

"Yes, Erin?"

"I need more honey. And bees."

“Honey? You mean—we have half a jar left.”

“I know, but I’ll need an extra jar for something special. You told me we can get it from the hive without Toren. Could you show me how you do that now, or is that no good?”

Lyonette hesitated. Her eyes went to Erin, and then the door. She hesitated, swallowed hard, and then stood straight and nodded.

“I can do it. Just give me an hour or two and I’ll be back with honey.”

“No, I’m coming with you. It’s dangerous, right? I’ll do it with you.”

Erin smiled at Lyonette. The girl smiled back. Both girls went over to the box of faerie flowers.

“They’re blooming nicely. Wow, I see new shoots already! Do you think it’s the mana in the inn?”

“It might be. Um—I’ll need to take a few, but the dead ones work best I think. We just need to start a fire in front of the bee cave you see—”

“Got it. What happens if the flowers don’t work? Do we run or hide?”

“Yes.”

“And if the bees start waking up when we’re in the cave?”

“...”

“...Let’s take all these flowers, okay?”

Erin grabbed empty glass jars as Lyonette found the sharpest knife in the kitchen. Both girls were ready to go when they heard an anxious whine. They turned and saw Mrsha, huddling by the door.

Mrsha was shivering. Lyonette hurried over to her and stroked Mrsha’s head as she whispered comfortingly to the Gnoll.

“You don’t have to come. In fact, you’re staying far away. And no following me this time, okay?”

The Gnoll licked anxiously at Lyonette’s face and reached for her, but Lyonette made her sit. Erin watched the two hug before Lyonette got up.

She was silent at first as they marched towards the cave in the snow. But then Erin felt compelled to speak.

“No one’s dying today. Right, Lyonette?”

“That’s right.”

The young girl’s face was set with determination. It was a long, hard march in the deep snow to the cave, but Lyonette knew the way and in short order she’d built the fire in front of the cave. There were ashes from the last one. Erin watched as she tossed the flowers in the fire and then both girls huddled in the snow outside of the cave.

It didn’t take long for them to hear the bees come after the fire—and then fall asleep. Lyonette hurried into the cave with Erin right behind her. The girl froze as she saw a sea of fallen bees resting on the floor, but Lyonette stepped past them towards the massive bee hive in the back. Despite harvesting from it several times before, the hive looked as obscenely bloated as before.

“Oh my god. I’d never have the courage to do that myself.”

Erin watched with admiration and horror as Lyonette began to slice into the hive, many times over as large as she was. It filled the huge cave, and Erin wondered how many bees were inside. She prayed they were all sleeping.

Then Erin remembered *she* had a job to do as well! She hurriedly fished around in the rucksack she’d brought and pulled out a pair of tongs. She began picking up bees and dropping them in the jars, counting as she did.

“One bee, two bee, three bees...this one’s twitching. Ew. Four bees, five bees, ooh, big bee! Seven bees...”

They worked in sweaty, quick silence until Erin had two jars of bees and Lyonette two jars of honey, honeycomb, and other parts of the hive. Then they hurried out into the snow.

“We made it! Are we okay?”

“I think so.”

Lyonette was pale, but triumphant. She was a mess, covered all over by the hive. She jerked her head back towards the inn.

“We should get away as fast as we can. The bees get really, *really* angry when they wake up. We don’t want to be anywhere near them.”

“Got it. Let’s go!”

Erin had to heft both jars as she struggled through the snow. They’d brought a small sled to carry the jars on, but the jars kept falling off no matter how the girls tried to lash them onto the sled—and they didn’t feel like trying to tie a good knot so close to the cave.

They made tracks, huffing and puffing as they tried to force their unwilling legs to move faster. When they were a good distance from the cave, Erin relaxed slightly.

“I think we might be okay. Lyonette, do you do that every day?”

“Yeah, but having someone else helps.”

Lyonette gasped as she panted for air. She looked at Erin with a smile of triumph and then turned pale.

“Erin. The jar...”

Erin looked down at the two massive jars she was holding and nearly screamed. The bees she’d put in the jar had woken up. And they were *alive*.

Normally they suffocated or died of the cold. But these bees, freshly put to sleep, were still able to move. And they did. They wriggled and tried to flap their wings obscenely in the crowded confines of the jar. The pulsating mass made Erin want to drop the jar, but she hung on for dear life, checking the lid to make sure it was *secure*.

“It’s okay. They’ll die quick. Let’s just put it on the sled and—I need to have a bath after this.”

“Okay.”

Gingerly, Erin lashed the two jars securely to the sled. The bees wriggled angrily and tried to sting her hands through the glass, but they could do nothing. Erin continued onwards, pulling the sled as Lyonette followed her.

“So you did this three times before I got here? That’s amazing!”

Erin was trying to be as congratulatory as possible, and she meant it. Lyonette really had turned over a new leaf, and this one was massive. The girl beamed with pride as they passed by a huge mound of snow sitting in the middle of a flat part of the snowy plains.

“I had to. Honey’s the only thing everyone really likes. It was so scary—I nearly peed myself the first time! But your flowers really are incredible.”

“I know. I’m wondering what else they might be able to do! I’ll do some experiments—hopefully I can grow enough so that—”

Danger. It wasn’t a word, just a thought, a bell rung at maximum volume in Erin’s head. She broke off and turned her head around immediately.

“Lyonette. Stop.”

The girl halted at once as Erin let go of the sledge and reached for the knife she always carried when she left the inn. Something was around them. She looked at Lyonette and the girl got the vibe at once. She drew closer to Erin as the [Innkeeper] eyed the ground.

“What is it?”

“[Dangersense]. But I can’t tell from where. Is it Shield Spiders? Are we at their nest or—”

A spark lit up Erin’s mind. They had just passed something. She hadn’t noticed, but it stood out to her suddenly. Why was a *mound of snow in a flat plain*—

She turned, just as the Rock Crab, camouflaged by the snow, stood up and sidled closer to her. It scuttled a few feet towards the girls, and then dropped down into the snow, looking like just another white part of the landscape. But Erin and Lyonette had seen.

It was less than fifteen feet away. Lyonette froze up and Erin felt her heart stop in her chest.

“Erin—what is—”

“Rock Crab. I told you—it’s too close.”

“W-what do we do? Run?”

“It’ll catch us.”

Erin knew that for a certainty. She clenched her teeth tightly, feeling the useless knife in her left hand.

“Seed cores would scare it away. But we don’t have any except at the inn!”

“In that case...”

“Just don’t move. I think it’s waiting for us to move. Let. Me. Think.”

Erin held very still as Lyonette shivered next to her. She knew the Rock Crab would strike sooner or later. When it did—

What could kill it? Adventurers. They were far away. Seed cores. Erin didn’t have any. Goblins? None around here since Rags was gone. Magic? No. Toren—

No. Erin closed her eyes. Fight while Lyonette ran for help? She’d be dead in a second. But if that was her option—

No. Wait. Something else struck Erin. She opened her eyes and stared at the sled she’d stopped pulling. At the things wriggling in the glass jars.

“Lyonette. Get ready to dive into the snow.”

“What? Wh—”

Lyonette’s eyes widened as Erin slowly, very slowly, waded over to the glass jars. Erin carefully lifted both jars of angry bees out of the sled, keeping her eyes on the mound of snow the entire time. Was it lifting up a bit?

She raised the first jar over her head and braced herself. Yes, the Rock Crab was moving. She saw it lift up, and then two long, flexible...

Were they eyes? Either that, or antennae. They stared at Erin and she stared at it. The Rock Crab hesitated, and then it lifted itself *up*, exposing a dark, red-brown body under its snowy shell and huge pincers that—

“*Duck!*”

Erin screamed and threw the first jar right into the Rock Crab's shell. *Inside* of it, in fact. The glass broke and Erin heard a roar of buzzing as the bees were freed. She didn't hesitate. She threw the second jar and then dove into the snow, digging herself deep as the bees buzzed in fury and the rock Crab *clicked*.

That was the sound. A deep, echoing *click* of a sea creature. It was a counterpoint to the thunderous buzzing.

Clickclickclickclickclickclickclickclickclickclickclickclick—

Erin didn't know if Lyonette was alive. She could only hear the bees, the crab—and then silence. The buzzing faded, growing more muted, but never completely ceasing, but the crab...

After a while, Erin chanced raising her head out of the snow. She looked around and saw the crab's shell, lowered to the ground. For a second she thought the crab was alive and her heart pounded wildly—but then she realized the truth.

"Lyonette."

The girl screamed when Erin found her in the snow. But Lyonette realized it was just Erin and came up to see what had happened.

"It's dead."

Erin pointed shakily to the Rock Crab's shell. She could see a few dead bees, smashed or in pieces around the shell, but only a few. The rest must have flown off. Lyonette stared at the shell and touched her ears.

"I can still hear buzzing though—"

"Yeah. The bees are *inside* the shell."

Erin pointed to the shell where she could hear the dim thunder of wings as well. Lyonette grew pale as she realized what had happened.

The Ashfire Bees had stung the Rock Crab to death—from the inside. But they were trapped in its shell as well. Both groups were dead or soon to be dead if no one disturbed them.

Erin laughed, shakily. Lyonette looked at her as if she were crazy, but then uttered a strained laugh herself. Both girls laughed and laughed and then Lyonette sat down and cried while Erin went to find their sled.

It was smashed on one end, but one of the jars of honey was intact. That would do. Erin brought it back and she and Lyonette made their way back to the inn.

Neither one said much. Lyonette was sticky with honey and other fluids from the hive. Erin held the jar of honey as Lyonette struggled onwards, wiping at her mouth and spitting occasionally. She said not a word of complaint, but Erin saw her shiver more than once as the cold air froze her wet clothing.

When they got back, Erin let Mrsha leap on Lyonette as Lyonette hugged her and cried in relief. Erin pointed upstairs as Lyonette tried to stop Mrsha from rubbing her furry body all over her honeyed one.

“Bath!”

Both Gnoll and girl looked at her. Erin smiled.

“Go take a bath, Lyonette. Don’t worry about cleaning or anything else. Just have a nice time—and bring Mrsha with you too! She’s all sticky.”

“I can make it quick—”

“No, no!”

Erin mock-scowled at Lyonette.

“Bath time is a special time. It’s the *most* special time. You take a long hot soak, or I’ll fire you. I’m going back into the city—after I talk with Octavia. Go on! Shoo!”

She waved at Lyonette and then remembered what else she wanted to say.

“Lyonette?”

“Yes?”

“Good work. I mean it.”

“But we lost the bees and most of the honey—”

“That wasn’t your fault.”

Erin looked sternly at Lyonette.

“You did amazing, getting us the honey. The Rock Crab...from now on, neither you nor I are leaving the inn without seed cores, okay? And we’ll be twice as careful—I’m going with you each time. But we survived.”

“Yeah. We did.”

They left it at that. Erin went to the kitchen with the jar of honey before she remembered what she had to do with it. She put the honey on a table and sat down for a second.

Only then did Erin let herself shake uncontrollably. She trembled so badly she couldn’t stand or hold the glass of water she’d poured herself; it slopped everywhere.

Just for a few minutes. One. Five. Then Erin stopped. She stopped shaking, stood up, drank the rest of the water in the glass, and sighed.

“I’m alive. I’m alive. I’m alive and—I need to get back to work.”

Erin stumbled towards the door. She had to come back and grab the jar of honey.

When she opened Krshia’s door this time, Brunkr was awake. Sort of. He was staring at his hand on the couch, not doing anything really. He didn’t look up as Erin came in.

“Go away, Human.”

“I have something that will help, Brunkr. I know how to help heal your hand.”

He looked up, full of hope and scorn. He frowned when he saw the huge glass jar of honey. Bits of honeycomb were stuck to the insides.

“What is that? Do you want to fatten me up before I lose my arm? Or is that for my aunt to sell?”

“It’s for you.”

Erin put the jar on the table, and turned to face Brunkr, hands on hips. She felt a bit better, although the smell of Brunkr’s infection didn’t help her stomach any.

“This honey is something Ryoka—do you know Ryoka? Well, it’s something that will help.”

“*How?*”

“What you’re going to do is—well, first, let me tend to your hand.”

Erin walked over to Brunkr. She’d brought a towel and a bag of salt. She put both down and he watched, confused and irritated as she found a basin. When Erin mixed some water she’d boiled in the kitchen with the salt he reacted poorly.

“You’re not splashing that on my hand.”

“I am.”

“No.”

He yanked his hand away as she reached for it. Erin glared at him.

“You need to get your infection clean. For god’s sake, why haven’t you cleaned it yourself? It’s disgusting!”

“It always comes back.”

He growled with gritted teeth as he backed away from Erin. She put her hands on her hips and glared at him.

“I’m washing your arm. With that water.”

“No. I’m not having you pour that on my arm. I’ve suffered enough without your crazy Human remedies!”

“I’m not giving you a choice. Come on—”

Erin reached for Brunkr and he hit her. It was a fast punch that caught Erin on the side of the face. It wasn’t too strong—for Brunkr. Erin stumbled back and shook her head. Then she threw up.

Brunkr eyed Erin as she panted and stared at the mess on Krshia’s floor. He saw the Human girl look at the vomit puddle, and then at him. He snarled, full of hurt and anger. But Erin just turned away and went into the kitchen.

She came back with more water and a cloth. It took a bit of time for Erin to get the vomit out of the rug, but she had a skill. She tossed the dirty water out, cleaned her hands. Then she stopped in the living room and stared at Brunkr. He stared back.

Erin sighed. She took two steps over to Brunkr and he raised his hand threateningly. This time Erin drew back when he clenched his fist. She eyed him—

And then hit him in the stomach.

“*[Minotaur Punch]!*”

Brunkr doubled over as Erin belted him. He swung at her, but she ducked. Erin stomped on Brunkr’s toe and punched him in the chest. He didn’t fall from that, so she kned him in the groin and then hit him in the face.

He hit her back. Erin stared up at the ceiling and then got up fast. She kicked the charging Brunkr in the groin again and shoved him on the couch as he doubled over, howling in pain.

“*Sit!*”

She shouted it so loudly the house rang. Brunkr tried to stand up—Erin raised a fist. He halted. His ears flattened, and the fight went out of him. He lay back on the couch and stared up at the ceiling. Erin breathed in and out heavily, and then reached for the basin of salt water.

“Does it hurt?”

“Yes.”

“Sorry. I need to get the wound clean, though.”

Brunkr hissed through his teeth as Erin carefully dabbed at his red wound. She pressed at it and she saw his claws sink into Krshia’s already threadbare couch—but he didn’t say a word.

“You’re doing great. I know it hurts, and I’m sorry. I really am. But you need to keep it clean. All this pus and nasty stuff? It can’t stay in the wound.”

Brunkr growled, vexation clear in his voice.

“I know that. But it keeps—agh! Keeps coming back.”

“So keep getting rid of it! Who’s tougher, you or pus?”

Erin scowled as she took away the dirtied rag and dipped it in another bucket. She sighed, and stared at his arm.

The red, gaping injury did look awful, but it was better than the oozing mess of before. She had—against Brunkr’s wishes—also snipped off a lot of the hair around the injury to keep it from getting in. Now Erin fetched the jar of honey.

“Why honey? It won’t work.”

“Have you ever tried using honey on your injuries?”

“Of course not. Who would—argh!”

Brunkr yelped as Erin began spooning honey over his infected arm. She coated his open flesh liberally, making sure it was all covered by a layer of glistening liquid.

“There. That looks right.”

“And this is supposed to do what? Heal me?”

“It’s a salve. It’ll help keep germs away. Um—keep the infection from getting worse, and make it better.”

Erin pointed to the jar as she got the bandages she'd bought out and began wrapping them around Brunkr's arm.

"Don't eat the honey, obviously. It's going to get really nasty over time I bet. Lots of hair, dirt...actually, wash your arm before you put the honey on it. But just *keep* putting it on, okay?"

He eyed her.

"When?"

"All the time! When you're awake, when you're asleep—all the time! If you can, keep honey on the injury every second. After you clean, again. Clean at least three times a day, and then reapply the honey salve. It'll help get rid of the infection. Here, I'll show you how to wrap a bandage over it..."

She finished tying the bandage over Brunkr's arm. He stared at it and shook his head.

"Don't you think I've done all this before? I've put the poultice the [Healer] gave me over my arm—it did nothing. I ate all the different meat my tribe mates gave me, I drank as many foul stews as my aunt made. Nothing worked. I burnt my wound with fire—"

"What? No wonder it's so bad!"

Erin glared at Brunkr. He glared back. He tried to put anger in his tone, but there was more defeat than anything else.

"Your cure isn't going to work. What makes a Human trick better than my people's knowledge? All you're using is *honey*."

"It may just be honey, but I know this honey works. Ryoka knows it works. It's not some quack medicine, okay? Cleaning your wound regularly, using honey and salt water—it's all part of the healing. You have to do it all or it won't work. Have faith."

He glared at her. Brunkr grabbed Erin's arm as she rolled up the rest of the bandage. It was a firm grip, but not meant to hurt.

“Faith? In what? This—this is just a fool’s cure. Why should I believe *honey* will cure...”

His voice broke.

“I will lose my hand. After this, it must be cut off. Not just my hand—my arm as well. I will lose it, and I will be a cripple. Not a warrior of my tribe—a half thing. Useless. Good only for the easiest chores.”

Erin stared at Brunkr. She didn’t know him. She’d only met him once or twice, and it always ended up in a fight, or so it seemed. But she could understand his fear, understand what he was going through.

“I know it’s scary. I know it’s hard to believe. But believe.”

“In what? In Humans?”

“No. In me.”

Erin grabbed Brunkr’s good arm with her own. She squeezed it hard, looking the Gnoll in the eye.

“Have faith in me. I want to help. And I know what I’m doing.”

He stared at her, and she saw the hope in his eyes that she was telling the truth. But then he looked away.

“Everyone says that.”

“I know.”

Erin sat with Brunkr as he let go of her and stared dully at his arm. She began tidying up in silence. After a minute, she spoke.

“You know, back home we don’t have magic.”

Brunkr looked up.

“You don’t?”

Erin shook her head as she sat the jar of honey in one corner of the room, balancing one of Krshia’s ladles on the lid.

“Nope. Not at all. Not a single [Mage]—heck, no one knows a single spell. Wild, isn’t it?”

“How could your people survive? Even we have [Shamans]. How do you... do anything?”

“With technology. With things other than magic. You see, we study a lot of things. We’re not tough like Drakes or strong as Gnolls...we don’t have good noses or the ability to cast magic or anything else. But we think a lot. And we write everything down. And one of the things we write down is how to cure people.”

“Everyone does that. My people have cures—if I were back at home and it were summer, my aunt says she could have found the good dirt—”

“No, see that’s where you’re wrong. We’re not the same. Where I come from, we *don’t* have cures. It’s not a mystery whether people will get well or not. We know what causes what, and if we don’t know, we find out. We don’t say you *might* get better. We invent cures that work all the time, or nearly all the time. That’s why I know the honey will help, and the cleaning.”

“Really?”

Erin nodded. She sat with Brunkr on the couch. He stared at her like Mrsha did to Lyonette when the girl talked with her. He wasn’t an adult, but a child, needing to believe all would be well. So Erin opened a door in her heart and remembered.

“I’ve heard of people who were blind being cured. I’ve seen people who lost a hand—and then had it sewn right back on! Where I come from...we don’t use healing potions. We don’t rely on alchemy or magic. We use *medicine*. And this—this is medicine.”

She pointed to the honey.

“It will work. It has antibodies—and it’s useful for fighting infections. When you need healing, you keep the wound clean and don’t let anything get on it. That’s the basics. I’m going to talk with an [Alchemist] after this and see about getting better medicine made, but this will do in the meantime.”

“And you’re sure it will work? How can you be?”

Erin met Brunkr’s eyes.

“I’m sure I’m doing the right thing. I’m not sure it will work. But I am sure that this is the only chance you have.”

It wasn’t what he wanted to hear. Brunkr looked away. Erin grabbed his paw. She waited until he looked back at her again.

“Believe me, please. If this doesn’t work, I’ll come back with a saw. Because you’re going to lose your hand otherwise. If you won’t do exactly what I ask...you’d better hurry up and chop your arm off before the rest of you gets infected. But until that day comes, I’ll tell you to do this. Because I know what I’m doing is right.”

The Gnoll stared at Erin for a long time. She could feel his pulse beating through his fur and skin.

“I wish I could believe you. I almost do.”

“Try?”

Brunkr hesitated. He looked away and sighed.

“I will try. I have nothing left to lose.”

“No. You have your hand to lose. But it’s not going to happen. It’s going to be okay. It’s *going* to be okay. Understand?”

She hugged him. The Gnoll froze, but Erin wrapped her arms around him and squeezed hard. Brunkr made a small sound, but she just kept repeating the words.

“It’s going to be okay. You’re going to be alright. It’s going to be okay. Your hand is going to get better. I’m going to come back and you’re going to keep changing your bandages, and it’s going to get better. I promise. It’s going to be okay. Okay?”

He said not a word, but put a paw on her shoulder. Erin felt him squeeze, and hugged tighter. She couldn’t see his face, but she felt him, as tightly as they were holding each other.

He was trembling.

When Erin left the apartment an hour later, she saw Krshia waiting for her outside. Snow had piled up in the Gnoll's fur, but she hadn't come inside. She nodded at Erin.

"I heard what you told my nephew. You give him hope. But it is not certain, no?"

"I didn't lie."

Krshia nodded.

"I know. And I will trust. And hope."

"There's more that can be done. I'm going to try and find something else that'll help more than the honey. I'll let you know. Just—help him, okay?"

"I will. He has hope, thanks to you."

Krshia hesitated. She bent closer to Erin and whispered, so softly that only the girl could hear it, not Brunkr, sleeping inside.

"I tell you, I did not believe when I gave him all those remedies before. I did not believe, because I thought his hand was lost. But you believe. I can smell it, and so can he. Thank you for that."

"That's just who I am. A silly believer."

Erin smiled. She squeezed Krshia's arm and the Gnoll hugged her briefly. Erin stepped away and walked out of the city.

She was tired. So tired. Erin yawned, and stared at the sun.

"Huh?"

It was just past midday. Erin blinked and rubbed her eyes. She felt so tired. So—incredibly tired. How was it only that early? But then she heard a

shout.

“Erin!”

Someone—a group of someones were waving at her. Erin automatically waved back and saw Pawn, Belgrade, Bird...walking together with Klbkch and the wonderfully strange blue Antinium. Further away, she saw Zel and the adventurers making their way to her inn.

Something like a sigh escaped Erin, although she kept a smile on her face. More people, all of whom wanted to see her, or at least wanted to eat something hot cooked by her. She felt so tired, so endlessly tired.

But the day wasn't over. And Erin had a job to do. She began to walk more quickly back towards her inn, and then stopped. She stared at the sky.

The sun was shining bright. It was shining in a sky full of clouds. Erin could see more on the horizon. Soon they would turn the world dark and grey, and pour snow down again. It would grow colder. The world would be washed away by ice once more.

But for a moment the sun shone. Then a cloud passed before it. Erin felt her spirits drop as the light faded. But it would come back. She had to believe that. She wanted to sleep a thousand years, but she looked at her friends and took a smile out of her heart and wore it bright on her face. Because if she didn't smile, who would?

The sun would come out again. Erin knew it. She whispered as she walked back to her inn, feeling exhaustion in every line of her body. It was a simple thing. It was all you had to do, even when everything else was uncertain.

“Have faith.”

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She didn't want to walk up the hill to her inn. No—it wasn't that. Erin didn't want to walk up the hill to her inn and go inside. Or...no, it was more like she didn't want to walk up the hill to her inn, go inside, and then have to feed and deal with another crowd of people right this instant.

Maybe in five minutes Erin would feel good about that, but right now she could only sigh as she stomped through the cold snow, up the steep and unreasonably treacherous hill, towards her inn.

It wasn't that she was tired. Well, she was tired, but it wasn't a physical thing. Erin was used to being on her feet all day long and working hard. She could fight off Goblins and cook pasta while picking blue fruit in the snow. But she'd been working hard of late. Very hard. And Erin felt just a bit...

Here was the problem. Erin wasn't just tired. That was a simple thing to fix. Tired was immediate, and solvable with sleep. It was a drain on the mind, a heavy little rock tied to the eyelids that made them close far too often.

Tired was simple. But Erin was exhausted. She just felt like—like—
“Like I need a holiday.”

Erin sighed as she trudged up the hill towards her inn. Everyone else had already disappeared inside; part of her was already thinking about what she could make for lunch. She hadn't had time for that because she'd had to go to Brunkr. Erin didn't regret that, but she knew the others would be hungry.

She was ready to apologize and get to work, but found to her great joy that Lyonette had already made something to eat!

“It's well, it's a fry-up with mushrooms and other greens. You can have it with fresh bread and I've got fried beef if anyone wants meat. It's got a Gnoll sauce on it, so it's a bit spicy...”

Erin sidled over as she saw the travel-hungry people lining up to fill their plates. Lyonette had put out a big dish of the fried veggies and meat for people to serve themselves buffet-style.

“You did all this?”

Lyonette nodded, smiling as she passed out plates. Erin resisted the urge to kiss Lyonette and instead hugged with one arm.

“You’re so cool. Best [Barmaid] ever!”

There was a plate, a fork provided by Mrsha, although it was covered with a few hairs, and hot food. For a few seconds Erin just chewed on crispy, crunchy green tubes and relaxed. The warmth went down into her stomach and made her feel alive again.

Then she looked around and took stock of her inn. It was a full room today. Not only had some of the [Wagon Drivers] stopped here to eat, but Pawn, Belgrade, and Bird and a small group of Soldiers and Workers were in line as well. Klbkch was conspicuous in his absence, as was the strange group of Antinium who’d followed him.

Erin went over to Pawn, thanking Lyonette in her heart—the girl must have figured out the Antinium might show up, hence the non-gluten meal she’d made. She smiled at Pawn and took time to welcome both Belgrade and Bird—she hadn’t seen them in what felt like forever!

The two other workers were almost shy as they bowed to Erin. Pawn was more relaxed, and showed the other Workers how to hold the plates properly—they had to do it for their Soldier counterparts, since the giant warrior Antinium couldn’t properly grasp the plates.

“I apologize, but I fear they will have to use their hands to eat, Erin. We will clean up any mess we cause.”

“Totally fine. Totally—don’t worry about messes. I’ve got a Skill! But if your uh, Soldiers have problems eating we can give them bowls.”

“That would help greatly. Thank you.”

A trip into the kitchen and the Soldiers had bowls to hold instead of plates. Erin smiled as she stood with the Antinium in line, watching the queue pass the buffet line. Everyone was hungry, but they’d stood aside to let the adventurers go first. And Zel. All the Drakes practically ushered him to the front, despite his reluctance.

“Klbkch sends his regards. He wished to meet you at the inn, but he has pressing business in the Hive. I believe he will attempt to visit you tonight, if his duties allow.”

“Of course he will.”

Erin sighed, but smiled at Belgrade. She watched as ahead of her, the Horns of Hammerad reached the table and began filling their plates.

“Silver and steel you two, eat *something* that isn’t meat or bread!”

Yvlon snapped exasperatedly at Ceria and Pisces. Both had gone for the sliced beef, completely skipping the vegetables. Ksmvr and Yvlon had a

more balanced plate, but the two mages looked completely unapologetic.

“I’m a half-Elf. I used to eat leaves for breakfast. I’ve had enough of them for one lifetime, thank you.”

Pisces nodded.

“And I—”

He hesitated, eyed the slices of beef and added two more to his full plate. Then he turned and walked away. Yvlon rolled her eyes and made a disgusted face, but she followed her friends to the table.

“My body is dead, so uh, I can eat unhealthy.”

Jelaqua grinned as she emulated Ceria’s style. Erin saw Lyonette hurry into the kitchen—probably to cook what meat they had left. Erin resolved to order a lot more from Krshia when she went to the city again. Her feet were already aching.

“If you’re dead, why would it matter what you eat? Surely you can’t taste anything.”

That came from Typhenous. Jelaqua turned, pretending to be offended.

“I’ll have you know that I keep my body’s tongue in perfect condition see? Now, some other organs are a bit the worse for wear, but taste is something everyone likes.”

“True. Now move, you’re holding up the line.”

Seborn edged past Jelaqua. He and Moore had balanced plates, Moore with more vegetable and bread than meat.

Griffon Hunt came next. Ulrien, Halrac and Typhenous got their food without objection, but when Revi reached the head of the table she took one look at the spread and made a face.

“I don’t like mushrooms.”

Halrac growled at her.

“Then get the beef.”

“I don’t want to eat just meat for lunch.”

Erin hurried out of line, already slapping her I’m-sorry-you-suck smile onto her face.

“What’s the problem, Revi?”

“Nothing here really appeals to me.”

The Stitch-girl turned her nose up at the food. Erin kept smiling.

“Okay, why don’t I make you a sandwich? Toasted bread, cheese, some sliced ham and greens?”

“I suppose that will do.”

Revi sighed and nodded. Erin hurried into the kitchen, but not before she'd passed Zel and heard him mutter.

"Mages."

It was the work of a minute to put together a lovely sandwich. No problem at all, really. But Erin had had to do it, which was what sucked. Lyonette was apologetic.

"I should have made something for Revi."

"No, you shouldn't. She's just picky."

Erin made a face as she used a pair of tongs to toast the sandwich to perfection by the kitchen fire. She pulled the sandwich away as her Skill told her it was done—it was like an egg timer going off in Erin's head—and tossed it onto a plate.

"You know, I've heard that when [Chefs] and [Waiters] don't like the people they're serving, they spit in the food."

"Ew! Do you think—do they really do that?"

Erin didn't see why Lyonette was so upset, but the girl was staring off into the horrific abyss of recollection.

"They didn't do that to my food—I'm sure of—but if I—"

She turned green. Erin waved a hand in front of her face and Lyonette came out of her trance.

"Well? I'm not saying you should, but..."

Both girls stared at the innocent sandwich. They shook their heads at roughly the same time.

"It's not worth it. Besides, that's disgusting."

"Yeah. It's not the sandwich's fault."

Lyonette nodded. She frowned, and then went over to the cutting board where some of the ingredients were left over. She took an unused mushroom and diced it up into very fine pieces, hiding them in the melted cheese. Erin smiled as Lyonette closed the sandwich.

"Hey Revi, you aren't allergic to mushrooms or anything, right? If it touches your skin, you won't break out in hives or swell up, because if you are—"

"I'm fine. Thank you."

Revi took the plate from Erin without a glance and began eating it with a knife and fork. Erin winked as Lyonette came out of the kitchen with more food for the buffet table. That was a small victory in her books.

"Oh, you don't need to eat the food here! I'm sorry, I forgot!"

She stopped Pawn as he was about to fill his plate. Lyonette hurried into the kitchen and came out with—

“*Bees?*”

The Drakes and Humans behind the Antinium took a step back. But all the Antinium perked up.

“I fried these in oil and then melted some cheese over them. Ksmvr says it’s good.”

Lyonette explained as she sat the Antinium at another table. With Erin’s help all of them had a few bees to eat, and Ksmvr came over as well to get his bugs. Erin sat next to Pawn and Bird, trying not to watch them eat as she slurped down her food.

Pawn was already pulling the legs off of his bee and crunching them down, but Belgrade and Bird stared at their food as if entranced.

“Well? Are you hungry? Or do you not like bees?”

“It is not that, Miss Erin. I have been waiting a long time for this moment. I wish to savor it.”

Belgrade stared at the bee dripping oil onto his plate. Bird stared at his bee and then picked it up. He spoke dreamily.

“They look like tiny birds. Bee birds.”

Erin glanced over, and saw Pawn and Belgrade shrug. She shrugged too, and began to eat. This was lunch. And since she hadn’t made it, Erin was a very happy [Innkeeper] indeed.

Work interrupted her before she’d finished eating, though. The door opened and a familiar blue-scaled Drake walked in.

“Erin?”

His face fell when he saw all of her visitors.

“If you’re busy, I can go. I’d hate to interrupt—”

“Olesm! No, I’m just finishing my lunch and Lyonette can serve everyone food and drinks. Uh, you can do that, right Lyonette? If you need a hand—”

“I’ve got two!”

Lyonette waved at Erin and smiled as she went past. Mrsha, trotting beside Lyonette, sat on her bum and waggled all four paws. Erin grinned and turned to Olesm.

“Want to sit? How about next to Pawn? You can eat mushroom stir-fry and tell me what’s happened, and then I’ll teach you all how to play Go!”

Olesm perked up and sat happily with Erin. He took one look at what the Antinium were eating and declined to have lunch.

“So, tell me everything that’s happened to you!”

“Only if you’ll tell me what happened! I heard a bit from Klbkch, but where did you *go*, Erin? That skeleton, Toren, did something, didn’t he?”

“You don’t know?”

A sea of Antinium and one Drake all shook their heads. Erin blinked.

“Okay. Then in that case, it all started when I was going to get more honey. I was in the sled with Toren pulling it and I took a tiny, *teensy* nap...”

Catching up with Olesm took half an hour of talk. Erin was aware of time passing and cut her story short, but she just *had* to pause when she’d heard what Olesm had done.

“A chess newsletter? That’s so amazing, Olesm! Can I subscribe? Oh—and what’s the latest puzzle? You do chess puzzles, right?”

Olesm’s light blue scales turned bright as he blushed. He traced on the table with a claw as Erin exclaimed over the letters he’d sent to other cities.

It was a simple collection of parchments, not anything like a magazine or newspaper. One was an annotated game—one of the ones she’d played, if Erin wasn’t mistaken!—and another was an explanation of how to read chess notation. Another paper held a chess puzzle someone had made.

“Ooh. Not bad.”

Erin solved the puzzle in three moves and handed it back to Olesm. His jaw dropped.

“You can’t have just—”

“I solved one like that ages ago. It’s good, though!”

“I got that one from the best [Strategists] in...oh, never mind.”

Olesm handed Erin another piece of parchment.

“Please, look at this.”

It was another annotated game, but not one Erin had played. To her eye, it was a fairly interesting back-and-forth between two decently skilled players. But what was really interesting was the attached commentary. Three full pages filled with comments from both players and two other [Tacticians] provided a decent analysis of every move made.

“Olesm, this is so *cool*. I’m so glad you’re doing this!”

“Well, I got the idea from watching you play. I sent some letters out and got a great response, so I’ve been sending more out each week! I’ve got

over twenty readers so far, and I'm told my letters get passed around to lots more people! And it's very profitable!"

Olesm puffed out his chest. Erin smiled. Internally, she was remorseful. She *never* had time to play chess anymore, or so it seemed! All that time in Celum and she hadn't picked up a pawn once. Chess was her *thing*!

"Can you give me all your old letters? I'd love to solve a chess puzzle or two."

"Erin, your puzzles are the ones I've been using!"

"Aw. No. Really? You've got to get more! And twenty people is great, but why not send this to [Tacticians] all over the world?"

"Don't stop there. Is the inventor of chess not Niers Astoragon? He and the [Strategists] in Baleros might find your work very useful."

Pawn put down the parchment he was holding and looked at Olesm. The Drake fidgeted in his chair. His tail lashed the legs of the table in his agitation.

"I wouldn't dream of sending my small work to him, but perhaps if someone were to mention it to Master Astoragon—well, I'd need for a lot more people to read my work before I'd be confident sending it to Baleros."

"Why? Because it's expensive?"

"Well...[Tacticians] are held in such high regard there, I would hate to embarrass myself. Not that I think your games are anything but perfect, Erin! But it's just..."

"You should do it."

Belgrade stared at Olesm. Bird looked up from his bee.

"Yes. I agree with what Belgrade is saying. You should do this thing I know nothing of."

Pressured on all sides, Olesm could only stammer about 'improving the quality of his publication'. Erin laughed, and decided not to push him further. He, at least, seemed like he was doing well on his own.

"Maybe you can add this to your next newsletter. I'll teach you all how to play Go while you're here!"

"Really?"

Olesm, Pawn, and Belgrade all sat up. Erin nodded.

"All we need are some stones and a board. I figure we can make one—uh—"

The Antinium stood up, Workers and Soldiers. They immediately filed out of the door. Erin blinked, and then saw them digging in the snow

outside through one of the windows.

“Um—okay! Let’s do this!”

“So, we have white and black stones. Two sides, like chess, see? And you’re capturing territory. You place the stones on the intersections, where the lines join like right here. Each stone can have up to four liberties—that means open spaces where a stone *could* go—in each direction like this. If you take away all the liberties, you capture the stone. Now, the goal is to get as much territory—as much of the board as possible—and as many captured stones as possible.”

Erin demonstrated, surrounding a black stone with white ones. She took it off the board and put it to one side.

“We call captured stones prisoners. And ooh, here’s something cool. You see these connected stones? Well, if they’re all touching each other we call that a string. And you can capture an entire string at once, but *only* if you take over all of their liberties. So that’s definitely something to watch for...”

Fifteen minutes later, Erin stood over a table where a bunch of white and black stones were sitting. They were freshly painted, and a bit tacky to the touch still, although a flame spell had baked the paint nicely.

The board for the game was carved into the table. It was just a huge block of equally-sized squares, nineteen lines long by nineteen lines wide. Erin didn’t mind sacrificing the table; you could still eat on it and she had a feeling a lot of games would be played in the future.

She was lecturing a crowd of people, not just Olesm and the Antinium. The Drakes and Gnolls were interested in this new game, and a few of the adventurers had come over to listen. Typhenous and Pisces looked particularly interested; Moore was jotting what Erin was saying down on a slip of parchment, and Ulrien and Halrac were listening while drinking.

The game of Go was simple, yet complex. It was all about capturing territory, which, when you got down to it, was at the heart of chess as well.

“Although chess is about completely eradicating the opponent’s pieces, I see many similarities in this game.”

“Yup. Most strategy games revolve around stealing an opponent’s territory. It’s pretty hard to lose all your pieces in a game of Go, but it *can*

happen. If you suck. A lot.”

Erin smiled at Pawn as she demonstrated how the game was played to her audience.

“The thing about Go is that—and I hate to say this, but it’s true—it’s far more complex than chess.”

“Really?”

“Oh yes. It’s very complex, but easy to understand. All you do is surround your opponent, but the game can take infinite forms. See, you can place a stone anywhere unless it means you’d lose it. So unlike chess...”

“There’s so much you can do.”

Olesm stared down at the empty board, seemingly daunted by its size. Erin smiled.

“I’m not as good at Go as I am at Chess, but I’m not bad. I used to study it and play games back home.”

“You did? I’ve never heard of it.”

“Well...”

Erin shrugged. She remembered staying up late at night, playing games online. She smiled sadly as she picked up a rough stone one of the Soldiers had smashed to make smaller and put it on the board.

“I used to play all the time. I was close to the professional level—not that I played half as much as I did chess. But I loved playing. Chess, Shogi, Go...it’s too bad I couldn’t gamble, because I can play a mean round of Mahjong as well. Anyways. Does anyone want to play a game?”

There were no shortages of volunteers. Erin soon found herself having Halrac carve a second and third board into the tables for people to play as the Soldiers went out to search for more stones.

“We really need round stones to play properly. But this is fine, I guess.”

“May I request your assistance in teaching me this game, Erin? I hope to learn as much as I can before Anand returns.”

Belgrade intercepted Erin before Pawn or Olesm could. Erin smiled at the Worker.

“Sure. Is that a bit of rivalry I hear?”

She was just teasing him, but the Antinium nodded to her great surprise. Erin blinked.

“I wish to beat Anand at this game. He is a better player than I, so I must practice more than he does.”

“Really? But I thought you two were closely matched. You were when I played you last time. Has something changed?”

Belgrade paused.

“Perhaps it is the difference of personality. Anand is far more decisive and bold than I. That is why he was chosen to remain behind at Esthelm. His ability to react to new situations is deemed invaluable. I can only memorize patterns and repeat them.”

He looked downcast. Erin reached out and patted him on the shoulder. Then she gave up and gave him a quick hug. As she did, she saw Zel standing by a far wall. He was watching the Antinium. Not with overt hostility like he did with Klbkch, but very intently. He was staring at Belgrade and Erin was sure he’d heard what the Antinium had said. Zel looked away the instant Erin saw him.

“Well, if Anand is so good at improvising, all you’ve got to do is study every chess move until you’re used to every possible outcome. Following your style isn’t bad, Belgrade. You’ve just got to be able to adapt.”

She led Belgrade over to a board and began to explain strategy. He shook his head dejectedly as Erin tried to get him to experiment while playing her.

“I fear making mistakes in experimentation. I prefer known strategy. I fear I will be poor at this game.”

“No you won’t!”

“But known tactics fail in the face of innovation. Anand is spontaneous, I am not. How can I ever defeat him?”

Erin had a reply ready, but to her intense surprise Zel came over and answered the question for her.

“Just because someone can adapt, doesn’t mean their strategy is better than a set formation. It’s a longstanding argument between [Planners] and [Leaders]. One kind—[Strategists] for instance—likes to plan for every eventuality. They see patterns in troop movements and in battle and react accordingly. But [Generals] like me just see opportunities. We act according to instinct.”

He nodded to Pawn as he walked over and stood over the board. He didn’t look happy, but there was something in the way Pawn turned to look at Zel that made Erin think they had talked before. Zel studied the board, frowning at the intersecting lines on which stones had been placed.

“There’s some overlap of course; most leaders learn basic formations and strategy, but there are few who can lead from the front and fight a war in their heads. But specialization isn’t all bad—you get weird freaks with classes like [Shadow General] or [Lightningstrike Commander] who can use one type of tactic very well.”

“Then I may succeed by using my set methods?”

“If you can adapt them for every situation, yes. Who’s to say one method can’t be used in most situations? So long as you have others who can support you—or you know when to retreat—I don’t see why not.”

That was what Belgrade needed to hear. He sat straighter and began to play a far more competitive game. Erin still beat him, but she felt good doing it.

“May I try?”

Zel took Erin’s place, and Pawn took Belgrade’s. This time the game was short. Zel bowed out as it became clear Pawn was the far better player. He shook his head as he let Pisces slip into the seat.

“It’s just black and white stones to me. I’m used to battles where no one takes turns and everyone’s slipping on blood and guts. But if it makes you level, I’m sure every [Tactician] south of Liscor will be begging for a copy of young Olesm’s next newsletter.”

Olesm beamed with pride. He looked at Zel like a hero, Erin recognized. And the [General] was, wasn’t he? Erin had a hard time imagining it, but Zel was a big hero. One of the biggest, according to what Pisces had told her.

“You should send this with your next newsletter, Olesm. And what about sending it north?”

“North? Well...I sent a few letters to Invrisil and some [Tacticians] I’d heard of, but I’ve really been reaching out to friends I regularly correspond with. They’ve been spreading the word in the Drake cities. You really think I should expand so soon...?”

“Yes! Send it to us Humans...and Gnolls too, for that matter! Why not? You should send some letters to a bunch of Gnolls—I’m sure Krshia could tell you who might be interested. Yeah, send like a dozen letters out for free. If they like it, they’ll reply back. If not...”

Erin shrugged. She sat Olesm down at a table as lunchtime turned into board-game time. Lyonette was already hurrying out with drinks and a snack, and Erin saw those not interested in the game heading out for the

city. It was only a little bit past midday. She had time. So Erin sat across from Olesm.

“Now, you’ve got a lot of good stuff, but have you considered having your parchment all stitched together?”

“Like a book? That’s costly.”

“No, not a book. It can be cheap. But you see, if you have a bit of color and maybe a little gossip, well, back home we call stuff like that *magazines*. I’m sure Krshia could find you someone who does a bit of artwork. You should have a little logo—ooh, and maybe a [Tactician] of the week! It’s good to reach out to your readers and get them involved. And while I’m on the subject, why not print a lot of issues of your newsletter and have them for sale in the Runner’s Guilds? If you do, then anyone can walk in and buy it. And if they don’t sell that well, it’s fine because you’re getting the word out. Now, my favorite part of newspapers back home is this thing called a ‘crossword’. It’s not chess, but...”

Things from home. Things she remembered. When you got down to it, that was what Erin truly had to offer to this world. She was just an average girl, but she’d brought part of the place she came from with her. That was what she could give, and that was what made Erin special, she felt.

Her memories of home.

Some of it was stupid. Some of it wouldn’t help. The people of this world took what they wanted, what was useful, and only that. No one had liked the idea of crossword puzzles, not even Pisces. The consensus was that if you were going to be silly about words, you probably had better things you could be doing with your time.

But not all of what Erin had said was pointless. She saw the value in it already, as Olesm strode out of the door, bursting with ideas for his newsletter. And she saw it in Pawn and the Antinium as they left for the Hive, already planning to introduce the game to the Workers there. A new board game had come to the city. It was a small thing, but it mattered.

Everything mattered. Small things became big things, like how a clean inn was wonderful. So Erin helped Lyonette clean up for half an hour after her guests had finished, and then told Lyonette she was heading out. Again.

Only this time, Erin didn't take the door leading to the outside world. She took the door to Octavia's shop.

"Hey Octavia! I'm—"

Erin stopped and stared. Octavia was standing at her counter and she had a customer.

The man at the counter gave Erin an odd look, mainly because she was staring at him like he was some new, undocumented species never seen before. He accepted a potion that bubbled brightly pink in a stoppered vial and hurried away.

"Who was that? Why was he here?"

"That was a customer, and he was buying a potion. What the potion was isn't your business."

Octavia scowled at Erin as the girl approached the counter. The [Alchemist] seemed irked today for some reason.

"Aw. You can't tell me? Why not?"

"Confidentiality. [Alchemists] don't reveal what they've sold on principle. You could be an adventurer or a [Barber], but some of what I sell —"

"Was it a love potion? Or...is it like a healing potion for something icky?"

Octavia ignored the questions. She glared at Erin.

"Do you need something? Or are you just using my shop as a rest stop?"

"I've got business! For you!"

Erin smiled at Octavia, but for once even the word 'business' didn't make the Stitch-girl jolly. Octavia folded her arms. Erin's smile slipped.

"What? Did I do something?"

"Oh, nothing. I'm just waiting for you to figure it out."

It took Erin a few seconds. She knew Octavia's shop had been the delivery point for all of Celum's goods and the people sent through, but it was for a good cause! So why—

Erin's head turned and she saw the problem. The front wall of Octavia's shop that led out into the street...was gone. Someone had knocked the entire wall down, and it was now patched up by a collection of plywood planks. It wasn't a good seal. Wind was blowing into the shop through the cracks.

"Oh. Uh, is that—"

"They knocked it in. To fit a *wagon* into my shop."

Octavia's tone could have frozen boiling water. She pointed at the front of her store.

"I was reimbursed for that, but hardly enough. You may note how I haven't had it fixed yet? That's because the cost of wood is very high in the winter. And guess who gets to pay for that? Not the city. *Me*."

"Sorry."

Erin took a deep breath. She felt guilty, and changed what she'd planned on doing. She put her hands on Octavia's counter.

"I'll pay you back for that. But can we talk business?"

The [Alchemist] wavered. An epic battle between mercantilism and personal irritation lasted for all of fifteen seconds, before she grudgingly nodded.

"What do you want?"

"I need all my magical soups. You know, the ones you were holding for me for a 'storage fee'?"

Octavia hesitated.

"I have them. I *may* have sold one or two—but I have your cut right here and I would be happy to reimburse you for the cost of—"

"Okay."

Erin didn't blink. Octavia looked at her, surprised, and decided not to question it. She went into the back of her shop and came out with a bunch of bottles full of soupy liquids.

"That will be—"

"Hold on, you can combine that with my next order."

"Next order?"

"I want you to do some research! I think you can make this one thing I want right away—it's called a 'match', and I need you to make it for me. Ryoka says it's simple, but this other thing is really hard. It's called 'penicillin', right, and—"

"No."

"Excuse me?"

Octavia glared at Erin.

"I said no. I'm not doing any more research for you. You're trouble. Every time I do something for you, I end up with a melted cauldron, or a hole in my shop, or a hole in my *wall*. I'm not helping you."

"What? But—I can pay."

"Too bad. It's not worth the cost."

“I think it is. Here—”

Erin reached for her money pouch, but Octavia snapped at her.

“Erin, no. I have several orders I need to fill, not to mention a *gaping hole in the front of my shop!* I won’t just let you—”

She broke off as Erin produced a fistful of coins. She slapped them on the table. They were heavy, thick coins. All gold.

Octavia swallowed. Hard. But she held her ground, though the luster of the softly glowing gold had fixed her eyes on them.

“A few gold coins won’t—”

Erin reached into her pouch and pulled more out. Octavia’s mouth stopped working for a few seconds.

“Look, I have a job to do and—”

Erin kept placing gold coins on the counter. She had to pile them up; she was counting. It wasn’t like she was made of money, but she had to make this right for Octavia.

In the end, thirty six gold coins sat in neat stacks of six in front of Octavia. The [Alchemist] gaped at them, and then looked up at Erin.

“That’s for your door, *and* hiring you. You can sell what I’m going to have you make, but I want to hire you. Is that okay?”

Octavia stared at the coins, and then looked at Erin. She glanced over Erin’s shoulder at the hole in her wall, and went back to the coins. Coins, Erin, broken wall. And then she threw her arms wide.

“Always a pleasure, *always* a pleasure to help my best customer! Hole in the wall? What hole? I was thinking I needed a new front for the shop anyways!”

Erin smiled. She looked Octavia in the eye.

“I’m really sorry, Octavia. I haven’t been a good friend to you.”

Octavia paused, and grew a bit more genuine as she raked the gold coins into a drawer.

“Well, it’s not like it wasn’t for a good cause. And the publicity! I suppose I can let it go. Especially if you’re paying me like this. Actually, for this rate, knock another wall down whenever you want! Now, what’s this about some experimentation?”

Erin smiled. She opened her mouth and then stared hard at Octavia. The [Alchemist] paused.

“What?”

“You haven’t eaten yet! Don’t pretend! I can tell when you haven’t—Lyonette!”

Erin opened the door to her inn and yelled into it.

“Get me some leftovers for Octavia, stat!”

Five minutes later, Octavia was eating from a plate as if she hadn’t eaten all week while Erin explained what she wanted.

“So what I want is a match stick, see? The thing you strike *and* the match box. Now, Ryoka says that the thing to make the side of the box is phosphorus. Um, red phosphorus.”

“What’s that?”

“I have no idea. It’s red, and uh, a rock, I think. It’s good for...igniting things?”

Erin raised her hands as Octavia’s face clearly showed what she thought of Erin’s description.

“I’m sorry! I don’t know! Ryoka could tell you more—ask her if you need details! But the match head is simple. It’s sulfur and other stuff. It just...lights up when you rub it on something. Like this.”

Octavia watched with interest as Erin demonstrated. She already had a sketch of the matches and matchbox, and she was tapping her fingers thoughtfully as she turned to look around her shop. At last she nodded.

“I can do some research and see what might work like this ‘phosphorus’. But look, Erin. *Anyone* can make fire with a flint and steel. Or a spell. And fire starters do exist. Ever seen a blaze bomb? Nasty. It’s made with the scales of an Ignition Salamander and Corusdeer horns you see, and when it explodes it—”

“I know it’s possible. But I bet it’s not cheap, right?”

“No...”

“This would be cheap. Really cheap. And easy! Okay, maybe people can use magic, but how many people use magic? And flint and steel is a pain to carry. Matches are useful—and sort of fun! I mean, I liked matches when I was a kid. Just try it, okay?”

“You’re paying me.”

Octavia shrugged and reached for her cup. Erin smiled.

“Now, the second thing I need is for you to experiment with mold.”

“Okay. Which kind?”

Erin paused. Octavia stared at her expectantly.

“I’ve got several growing in the back if you want any one particular kind.”

“Of course you do. Well, this one’s green and sort of blueish, and it grows on oranges and bread...”

“How much do you want? I don’t grow that, but I think I’ve got a loaf of bread in one of my cupboards that probably has that kind of mold.”

“Just...wait a second, okay? I need something specific. You see, I need penicillin, which is a special type of mold. It works like this...”

Octavia frowned as she listened to Erin’s description. When Erin was done, Octavia was willing to admit that penicillin might be very useful, but she had no idea how to figure out which mold would work like that.

“I guess I can experiment on myself? No? Well, perhaps a test subject. I guess I can get a pig or sheep or something and...no? Aw, come on. How about a rat? Aw, Erin—okay, I’ll do all I can. But I still have to run my shop. And brew potions. Honestly, the brewing is easier than the shop keeping—I need to stay behind the counter at all hours. But that’s going to cut into the amount of time I can keep researching, just so you know.”

Erin blinked at Octavia and a little candle lit up in her head.

“I can help with that. Come to the inn tonight for dinner and we can talk details.”

Octavia eyed Erin and then raised a hand.

“No way. Sorry, Erin, but no. Honestly, I appreciate the thought, but you’re no expert saleswoman, and I can’t just turn my merchandise over—wait, where are you going? I didn’t finish! I’ll let you try to sell my stuff if you’re willing to give me a cut of—”

Erin waved at Octavia as she exited the shop. The [Alchemist] frowned as the door—or rather, hinged piece of plywood—swung almost shut. She went over to it and pushed it closed, muttering under her breath.

“Gotta improve the pitch, Octavia. You have to get them hooked faster. Fifty percent? Hah! *Eighty percent* cut, and then you start laying on the little extras. Market value purchase plus city taxation, labor costs, regional import fees, cauldron taxes...”

A minute after Erin had left Octavia’s shop she stopped and slapped a hand to her forehead. A passing horse and rider looked at her weirdly, but

that was alright.

“Healing potion slimes! That’s right!”

Erin snapped her fingers and fished around for the piece of parchment to write that down. Then she went on her way.

There wasn’t enough time in the day for everything she needed to do. From Octavia’s, Erin made a beeline to the Frenzied Hare in Celum. She was a bit leery of inviting Agnes to the Christmas party, but happily the woman was out.

Unhappily, *everyone* was out of the Frenzied Hare. The doors were locked, and Erin had left her key to the building back in her inn. When she asked why it was closed, she learned that Miss Agnes had taken a holiday with her sick husband. That essentially meant spending all the coin Erin had helped her earn by staying at someone else’s inn and eating lavish food.

Erin just shook her head when she heard that and asked where she could find Wesle, Jasi, and the other actors. She was pointed to a building that had been bought out by the troupe of [Actors]—a freshly painted sign advertised nightly performances.

“Presents?”

Jasi blinked at Erin as she turned from their rehearsal of *My Fair [Lady]* to talk. Grev, hovering backstage with water and the scripts for the actors, looked up sharply.

“That’s right!”

Erin smiled at the younger Drake as she explained about Christmas for the umpteenth time. By the time she was done, Grev was a new convert to the dream of getting presents for free, and Jasi and some of the other [Actors] including Wesle were happy enough to join in Erin’s present-giving program.

“So you’ll tell us who we’re getting presents for, right? Can you tell us now? If it’s in two days, I’d like to get started shopping right away.”

“Uh—I’ll have a list by tonight!”

Erin promised the troupe as she tried to figure out how best to do that. She’d probably need a list. Or a diagram. She should have bought more parchment and ink!

Jasi caught Erin as the girl was getting ready to get back to her inn—this time to get ready for dinner.

“If you’re making everyone give gifts for each other in secret, do you mind if I ask that you let me buy a gift for Grev?”

“Of course!”

Erin smiled at Jasi.

“You’ve gotta get one for him, and I’ll make him get one for you! Anyone else you want to put on the list? Maybe Wesle?”

“Maybe.”

Jasi blushed and fiddled with her claws as she looked the other way. Erin had a thought.

“Or maybe Olesm! He’s a Drake, like you! Not that it matters, but it could be a good way to introduce yourself to him. I know you don’t know many Drakes since you live in Celum...”

“Maybe not, Erin. I mean, I don’t know other Drakes. I wouldn’t know what to buy. But maybe instead of Wesle, you could put down that Pisces guy? He’s handsome.”

Jasi smiled. The smile faltered as Erin gave her a look flatter than paper. Without a word Erin backed towards the door and then shut it. Then she opened it again to smile.

“I’ll do my best!”

She paused.

“But seriously, no. Pisces? No.”

She shut the door again.

That night, the Wandering Inn saw a record-breaking number of guests. Again. Word had spread about the game of Go, and Erin had more than a few visitors who came just to sit at the tables and play with the now vaguely-round stones.

There was a lot of competition, and Erin was touched to see the Antinium playing against Drakes and Gnolls with scarcely a second glance. Pawn and Belgrade were among the better players in the room, and that was including the mages and Olesm. Pisces seemed to have a knack for the game, but those who practiced strategy for a living still had an advantage over everyone else in the room.

Except for Erin. She was delighted beyond belief to have actually lost a game—an event which made Olesm race outside and dance about the inn for ten minutes straight—but she was still a better player than everyone else by sheer virtue of practice. But she was happy. Happy, though she was

having trouble standing up. Her legs were *aching* and her arms hurt from hauling a bunch of frozen meat back to her inn.

Klbgch didn't come that night, but Relc did. He slipped into the inn, hesitating a bit when he saw Erin. But she pretended not to see him at first, and instead helped Belgrade as he played a very close game against Olesm.

"Ooh, an apple!"

Relc spotted a plate with apple slices sitting on a table. After a surreptitious look around, he happily crunched down the slices, still as fresh and as crisp as when they'd been cut, which was yesterday.

Erin stared at Relc, and then smiled.

"Everything going well?"

"Hm?"

He jumped guiltily and then turned to her.

"Oh. Hey Erin."

"Hey, Relc."

They stood in silence for a few seconds. Then Erin gestured to the table.

"Want some food? Today's dish is beef broth, mashed potatoes, roast beef, gravy, mushroom-and-meat skewers, boiled greens—those tube greens, you know—and honey-drizzled steamed carrots. What would you like?"

Relc gave Erin a pleading look.

"Can I have...everything?"

She smiled. Some things didn't change. In this at least, she was glad.

"Sure. Coming right up!"

When he was eating happily, Erin sat with Relc and—talked. Just for a little bit.

"So you've really been good?"

He paused, licking the spoonful of potatoes with a long tongue.

"Can't complain. That damn dungeon's spitting out monsters now and then, but Captain Z's got us guarding in shifts and we've built some fortifications. Really, the most annoying part is all the adventurers coming in and out."

"Why, are they rude to you?"

"Yeah! They look down their noses on the way in, and on the way out they run to us with their tails tucked between their legs, begging us to stop the icky monsters."

Relc laughed and Erin smiled.

“Sounds like a lot of work. I’m just glad you’re okay.”

“Well...you know me. I’m tough!”

Relc thumped his chest and looked sideways at Erin.

“You got rid of that skeleton thing, right?”

“Yeah. I had to.”

“Good. I mean, it was going to go bad. You can’t trust the undead.”

“I guess not.”

“And the uh, Goblins are gone. I didn’t do anything!”

“I know.”

Silence. For once, Erin didn’t have much to say. Relc was a friend. He had been a friend. But after a while, she stood up.

“If you want anything else, just yell. Lyonette and I can handle it.”

“Sure.”

Relc turned awkwardly to his food. Then he looked at Erin.

“That Gnoll kid you’ve got there—I heard some of the guys talking in the barracks about her. White fur’s bad, right?”

Erin hesitated.

“I think so. To Gnolls.”

“Yeah. But they’re stupid. It’s good that you took her in. Real good.”

Relc and Erin paused, full of words unspoken. Then Erin nodded and walked away. Someone was calling her name.

She chanced upon the Horns of Hammerad after she’d helped serve more alcohol. They were sitting at their own table, talking amongst themselves. The topic happened to be the items Ryoka had analyzed.

“We couldn’t get a reply from her, but what she said sounded good. Really good.”

Ceria told Erin as she slid into a seat. The half-Elf sounded like she was half-trying to convince herself. Yvlon nodded, as did Ksmvr, but Pisces looked less sanguine. Ceria began listing off the items, keeping her voice low as she whispered to Erin.

“A magical sword with the weight enchantment—a good one. That’s powerful. A buckler with a spelled defense? That’s Gold-rank gear right there, for Yvlon probably. And that dagger? Valuable. Pisces, you or I could use it, or Ksmvr could wield it in his off-hand...”

“And that’s all.”

Pisces took a deep draft from his tankard.

“That’s all, Springwalker. We don’t know more, so we don’t know if that’s it, or if Ryoka found something truly of worth.”

“She didn’t tell you anything else?”

Yvlon shook her head.

“She promised us that there’s more, but she was only willing to list those three weapons in case someone was reading our messages. I’d worry someone might try to steal the artifacts, but if she’s travelling in Magnolia Reinhart’s coach...”

“It might be that she was trying to spare our feelings.”

Pisces slumped in his chair. He seemed morose. Ceria shook her head.

“I don’t believe that.”

“Why not? Those are all of the weapons we recovered. Save for the sword blade—broken. What else could be of worth?”

“Plenty. There was that bag of holding—and the enchantments on the weapons *are* powerful.”

“I suppose they are.”

Pisces sighed as Ceria began listing the things that might be hidden inside the bag of holding they’d found, or the adventurer’s pack. Yvlon listened, occasionally adding a suggestion, and Ksmvr sat, looking from Pisces to Ceria.

The Horns of Hammerad were more nervous than happy about the items Ryoka had identified. Erin wondered if there really were more artifacts than the three weapons. It didn’t matter. Either way, her goal was to raise their spirits, so Erin interrupted Ceria and began explaining Christmasian theory. Again.

“Presents? I guess we could go out shopping. Only...”

“I’ll lend you some money. You can pay me back. I know you’re good for it.”

“Some adventuring group we are.”

Yvlon shook her head, but she was smiling at the thought of Christmas.

“You know, we did something similar. It wasn’t something as large as a present, but we’d get sweets during the winter solstice. I used to look forwards to that every year.”

“Sweets is a good present! Uh, especially since I didn’t make the list yet.”

Erin winced as she realized she’d have to run around and tell everyone who their secret two people were tomorrow. She left the Horns of

Hammerad as she spotted someone else in the crowd.

“Selys! *Selys!*”

“Erin! Where have you been? I haven’t seen you for ages!”

The two laughed and sat down at another table. Selys was just about to tell Erin all about her troubles managing the guild with so many new adventurers when Erin remembered her magical soups and hurried into the kitchen to get them. She called over Halrac and some of the other adventurers as she explained how they worked.

“What do you think? Can I interest you in any of it?”

Ulrien, Halrac, Seborn, and Selys all stared dubiously down into the jar of blue, thick soup Erin had opened. It did not look appetizing, but after a second Halrac picked up the jar. He sniffed it once, and then gulped a mouthful down. Selys shuddered. Halrac’s face didn’t change as he handed it to Ulrien.

“Not bad. We don’t need it, but I can mention it to some [Scouts] I know.”

“You think they’d want it?”

Halrac raised his eyebrows.

“This? Oh yes. If they can move around with less clothing on, it’s less to carry and less noise. They’ll buy it.”

“Adventurers too. Anyone wearing armor in the snow will want this.”

Ulrien made a face as he swallowed. He pushed the jar over to Selys. The Drake raised her hands.

“I can get grandma—uh, the Guild to sell this. But I’m not drinking it.”

“Aw. Come on Selys, it’s not *that* bad. And it works! Just try it!”

“No.”

“Please?”

“No, Erin.”

“Pretty please?”

“No.”

“Well, okay. But wait until you see *this* potion! It makes your skin tough! Do you want to try it, Seborn?”

Sitting across the room, drinking some hot beef broth and wondering if she could get in on Erin’s business transaction, Octavia was just about to get up when a shadow blocked the light. She looked up and saw a Gnoll.

That wasn’t surprising around Liscor, Gnolls being a good percentage of the city’s population. But Octavia had met few Gnolls in Celum. She gulped

as this one loomed over her. It—she—spoke in a deep, growling voice.

“Hrm. You are Octavia, yes?”

“Yes?”

Octavia squeaked. Krshia smiled, baring all of her teeth.

“I am Krshia. A [Shopkeeper]. I am told you may wish to let me sell your potions, yes? Let us talk business.”

“You? But I—did Erin—”

Octavia glanced helplessly towards Erin, but Krshia had already pulled out a seat. Octavia did her best to pull herself together. A customer was a customer, and she was a master at selling.

“Well, Miss, uh, Krshia, I’m one of the three best [Alchemists] in Celum. I don’t like to brag, but I’ve sold potions to Gold-rank adventurers and I get commissioned regularly to do research creating new potions. Now, my brews might not be the most standard, but I can assure you that my percentage is quite reasonable. A fifty percent cut of all profits is a good place to start, but I could—”

“Mm. What is your level?”

The [Alchemist] broke off nervously. Krshia was just staring at her, unblinkingly.

“My—my level? Well, I think that’s a personal issue, and as we all know, levels don’t always correspond to Skills of c—”

“I will sell your potions, but if they are lower quality, I must price them as such, yes? And then...well, we shall see. I have many levels in my class, and that must be weighed, yes? If I, a high-level [Shopkeeper], were to sell your potions, I should get a better cut, yes?”

“Well, yes, but no, but—let’s talk effort here. I’m brewing the potions —”

“But I sell them, yes? I must sell your potions. If I do not sell, no one will buy, yes? So which is more important?”

“Hold on—if I didn’t make potions—”

Octavia’s mouth was dry, but she didn’t dare take a sip from her cup. She was fighting for something far more important than her life. The battle for the bigger bottom line was fought quietly in one corner of the inn. Tears were shed, and a little bit of blood. But on the whole, Erin thought she’d done a good job, especially when she saw the look on Octavia’s face afterwards.

“It’s a pain in the ass.”

Halrac was talking to Erin at a table late at night. She was trying to look as attentive as possible. She hadn’t gotten a chance to speak with him since she’d come back, and she knew the man wanted to talk with her, even if he wouldn’t say it.

That was how the night was going. Sit at a table and chat. But don’t sit too long, because someone else would want to speak with her. Erin’s eyes hurt. She wanted to close them, but her friends were more important.

“How’s it a pain? I mean, this *is* a dungeon so I know there’s lots of monsters...”

“Monsters we could handle. If it were a nest we’d deplete their numbers and destroy their home. But this is a magical dungeon, one where the rooms keep changing. A trap room we disarm one day might be gone the next, and in its place an entirely new trap, or a room full of monsters.”

“And the traps are really bad, right? I’ve heard stories from Relc.”

“They’re some of the worst I’ve seen.”

Halrac shook his head, looking grimmer than usual.

“I’ve seen deadlier—the one that got your friends is probably worse than most of the ones in this dungeon. But there are so many that we can’t make any headway. And when we come back the next day...”

“They’ve changed.”

Erin whistled quietly and Halrac nodded. He took a sip of the drink Erin had made especially for him. There was just a drop of the faerie flower nectar in it, enough to take the edge of the day off.

“So far, a lot of kids have gotten killed and the others are making no headway. We’re the only group that’s gone in, and we have nothing to show for it.”

“Is there any hope? Or do you just...have to get lucky?”

Halrac shrugged.

“Right now we’re trying to identify all the rooms on rotation. If we can figure out the trick behind most of them, we might be able to break through to the next area. Then it’s just a matter of anchoring ourselves at that point. There are ways to stop a magical dungeon from changing. But it’s the crevasse the Mrsha child found that interests me. It goes straight down into another part of the dungeon.”

“And that’s good, right?”

“Maybe.”

The [Scout] seemed incapable of optimism. For good reason, as he explained to Erin.

“The problem with that is if we go down there, we’re walking into an attack on all sides. Multiple traps with wide ranges might come at us, and there are plenty of strong monsters down there. The dungeon is *infested*. When we went down to save the child, we ran into eight different species, some of which were fighting each other. If we hadn’t all been high-level, we wouldn’t have made it out.”

“Thank you for doing that, Halrac.”

“It was nothing. You should thank Zel Shivertail instead. He was the one who killed the most monsters.”

“Do you think he’d like to go into the dungeon with you guys?”

Erin saw Halrac smile, just once. She smiled too; her mission was partly accomplished.

“Him? He’s no adventurer. I wouldn’t have ever expected to fight beside him, but it was...good to see. But he wouldn’t risk his neck down there. It’ll be us.”

“And it’s worth doing?”

“Who knows?”

Halrac raised his eyebrows.

“There could be nothing down there, or an artifact beyond our wildest imagination. But we’re going to look anyways, because that’s what adventurers do.”

“Well, you can stay as long as you like. And I’ll have good food and a warm bed for you—and I want to see if Pisces really can rig up some kind of emergency teleport stone. If he does...I want you to all have one.”

Halrac smiled.

“You’re an odd [Innkeeper], Miss Solstice.”

“I know!”

“Thank you. It’s...pleasant being here.”

Erin smiled at him, and felt her eyes threatening to close.

“That’s all I want to hear. Would you like a refill?”

And then it was night time. Somehow, everyone had vanished, leaving Erin alone in her inn. She sat at a table, head resting against the wall. It was dark. Snow was falling. Everyone had gone.

And Erin was beyond tired. She was so tired she had passed into that special realm where she was too tired to sleep. She stared out the window as the snow fell and made to bury the world. One last hurrah, before the weather turned and the world slowly began to warm.

“It’s going to be very, very deep tomorrow...I’ll have to shovel it... can’t open the door I bet...”

Erin murmured dreamily to herself, slurring the words. They were just fragments of thought, things she had to do. She had so much to do.

“I forgot to get a Christmas tree. Oh well. I guess I can try tomorrow...”

One day to get everyone to buy presents. She had to figure out who would get what first—probably before she talked to anyone. So now or before dawn. And Erin had to get presents herself, get ready for the party—buy more food, figure out traditional Christmasy foods, decorate the inn...

If she pushed the date back she’d have more time. But Christmas came before the New Year’s, didn’t it? And the winter solstice was...well, as close to a New Year as this world had. The Frost Faeries probably only cared about the solstice, anyways.

“Solstice.”

Erin stared out the window. She breathed and the glass fogged up. Erin wiped away the condensation and stared into the snowy landscape.

So tired. But she’d done good, hadn’t she? She’d brought a game to this world, talked with everyone, helped Krshia, Octavia...but she was tired.

So tired. She’d wake up in a few hours. Before dawn. She had a lot to do. So Erin should sleep. She knew that. But she was too tired for that. She just wanted—well, she wanted so many things. But right now she just wanted to sleep.

Was today a bad day? No, it was good. Then why did Erin feel hollow inside? Miserable? Why would she feel like that?

If you’re sad, just smile. Had someone told Erin that once? Or was it just something she’d grown up knowing?

Her lips twitched. Erin smiled, and then let it fade. She stared out of the window, resting her head against the wall. Not crying. Not smiling. Just staring.

She felt just a little bit tired.

At some point, Erin fell asleep. But she wasn't quite asleep. She hovered between waking and slumber, so that reality became a dream, but she was still thinking.

Smiles. She'd seen them today. That was what she'd set out to collect, like Santa getting his presents or the tooth faerie flying from bed to bed. They were such brief things, smiles. But they were so valuable. And Erin had collected so many...

A smile from Krshia. Brunkr's bared teeth, determined, hopeful. Mrsha's big smile as she licked honey off a paw. Lyonette's mischievous grin as she fed Revi mushrooms. Relc happily eating the apple. Octavia and her gold. Jasi, performing. Bird, eating bees...

Fragments. In her dream, Erin reached out and gathered the glowing shards to herself. They were the one light in a dark world filled with snow. But when she touched them, they melted and dripped from her hand. They fell down into the blackness and became stars. Erin looked down and found herself staring up into the sky. The clouds were gone, and the stars shone down. She smiled then, and she was smiling when Lyonette found her asleep the next day.

And the word that spread through the city, through two cities, was simple. It was a word never heard in this world before, a word that would not topple kings from their thrones or start revolutions. But it was a special word, nonetheless. It was something new, something that might be important, or might not. It was as important as people thought it was. But it was special to the girl who lay sleeping in her inn, too tired to lie down. It meant happiness. It was a word for joy, a word for the season. A word of power. A word from home.

A memory.

Christmas.

3.40

When Ryoka left the Mage's Guild she found Reynold waiting for her. The young woman was not surprised; she let the [Butler] fall into step beside her as she walked slowly down the street.

Reynold was not smiling. Not that he was usually beaming; but he normally carried himself with professional impartiality. Right now he was *not* smiling and it was quite clear he was also not happy.

"Miss Ryoka. I trust your visit to the Mage's Guild was eventful?"

"You tell me."

"I trust I conveyed Lady Reinhart's wishes to you earlier? My duty is to accompany you as an escort—"

"Yeah. But I'll just bet that I had other people watching me while you were busy with Laken. Stop glaring, Reynold. I'm not in a good mood right now."

Reynold glared, but he decided to shut his mouth after a second of wavering. Ryoka saw him glancing at her face. In truth, she wasn't angry. She was more tired. No; tired wasn't the right word.

Valceif Godfrey was dead. It felt like no one in the world knew or cared. But Ryoka did. She cared, but she had to finish her job here. Then she could go back and—tell everyone. Tell Erin, and Hawk, at least.

"How'd it go in the Merchant's Guild?"

Ryoka frowned at the sky as she spoke. It was quite dark, although it shouldn't have been so early. The clouds had completely obscured the sun and snow was beginning to fall. A *lot* of snow.

The [Butler]'s voice was testy as he replied.

"Mister Laken has concluded most of his business to his satisfaction. A shipment of goods and food has been paid for—and two adventuring teams have been contacted. If all goes well, they should be ready to begin transport this very night."

"Good. Thanks for helping him."

"It was my pleasure, Miss Ryoka. It is my privilege to serve others in need of my assistance...whether I like it or not, apparently."

"Hah. You're a lot more fun when you're upset, Reynold."

Ryoka half-smiled as she turned to look at him. Then she looked up again. Ryoka frowned and prodded at her belt pouch.

“Ivolethe? Hey, Ivolethe. What’s with all this crap floating down? We’re already up to our knees in the snow; why do we need *more*?”

She saw the pouch at her belt rustling, and then Ivolethe poked her head out. The Frost Faerie grinned as she spread her arms wide at the dark, snowy sky.

“Ah, you see it? Do you see your doom, floating down from above? Prepare for wrack and ruin, ye mortals! This snowstorm will be the greatest in a century, nay, in ten thousand years! The snow will cover the earth and leave none alive! This is the dawn of a new age of ice and woe! Alack! Despair!”

Ryoka stared down at Ivolethe with narrowed eyes. The faerie stared back, blinking innocently.

“What does ah, Miss Ivolethe have to say, Miss Ryoka?”

“She says we’re all doomed.”

“Oh.”

“Yep.”

The two Humans didn’t react the way Ivolethe was hoping for. She scowled, and then answered in a sulky tone of voice.

“A blizzard comes. You will see it become strongest by nightfall. It will last two...nay, three days at most. If you hide in your small huts of wood and stone, you should be fine.”

“Thanks for the weather update. Buh-bye.”

Ryoka closed the lid on her belt pouch. Ivolethe made a sound of pure outrage; Ryoka winced as her pouch instantly frosted over. The faerie pushed the lid open as Ryoka turned to Reynold.

“Is Laken still at the Guild? I want to speak with him.”

“I believe he has retired to his lodgings for the moment, Miss Ryoka.”

“Okay. Where are they?”

“I regret to say that he did not inform me.”

“Okay. Where *are* they?”

Ryoka stopped and turned to face Reynold. She folded her arms and scowled at him.

“Don’t play games, Reynold. I know that someone followed them.”

He just shook his head, stepping to one side to allow a group of laughing Gnolls to pass him by.

“Miss Ryoka, you assume that other servants under Lady Reinhart’s employ would be following you. I regret to inform you that this is not the case. There are a finite number of people who serve her, and it is hardly useful to send a [Maid] or a [Waiter] to follow someone.”

Ryoka rolled her eyes.

“Look, Reynold. I don’t have to see someone to know they’re there. I know Magnolia’s type. Someone’s following me, and probably Laken as well by now. Now, we can wander around while you pretend you have no idea where Laken is, or we can skip that and just ask your friends.”

“I’m afraid I cannot help you, Miss Griffin.”

“Right. In that case—Ivolethe? Where’s the nearest spy?”

The Frost Faerie, who’d been poking her head out of Ryoka’s belt pouch, brightened up. She smiled wickedly at Reynold. He was shaking his head almost imperceptibly at her. But Ivolethe ignored that as she gleefully pointed a finger into the crowd of pedestrians.

“There!”

Ryoka turned her head and saw an old man with a horrible skin condition—some kind of puffy warts on the right side of his face—slowly moving down the other side of the street. She ignored Reynold as he tried to block her and strode right for the man.

“Hey, you.”

The old man didn’t notice Ryoka at first, but he eventually stopped when she stepped in front of him and blocked his way. He swayed back, staring uncertainly at her—and then avidly at her breasts. He looked confused as Ryoka stared at him.

“Eh? What do you want, Miss?”

The young woman ignored the scrutiny. She stared down at the elderly man as Reynold hurried to her side, looking anxious.

“Where is Laken Godart?”

“Who? I don’t know who that is. What do you want?”

He tried to move past Ryoka. She blocked his way again. Now the old man was looking anxious. He looked exactly like an old guy – he even smelled old, if old was a smell. Nonenal, Ryoka thought it was called. She glanced down at her belt pouch, suddenly not entirely certain.

“Ivolethe, I swear, if you’re messing with me I’ll be really pissed.”

“I’m not!”

“Miss Ryoka, please—”

Ryoka turned to glare at the [Butler].

“Shut up, Reynold. Look, I know you’re in Magnolia Reinhart’s employ. Are you going to give up the act, or do I have to make a scene?”

Ryoka stared down at the old man, not quite making a fist. The old man glanced at Reynold. The [Butler] spread his arms helplessly behind Ryoka’s back. After a second, the old man sighed. He reached for a ring on one of his gnarled fingers and *twisted*—

A [Maid], wearing a frilled dress and peeved expression on her face, straightened up in the middle of the street where the old man had been standing. The people around her did a double take, but Ryoka just smiled.

“Nice ring.”

The woman was in her late twenties, or early thirties. She had a tight bun of dark brown hair and an expression that naturally lent itself towards severity. Or maybe she just had a Skill that made her look that way. She didn’t quite glare at Ryoka.

“This way, Miss Ryoka. Your friend is staying at the Crag Pig, quite a few streets away from here. If you will follow me...?”

It was a short and uneventful walk to the inn Laken was staying at. Uneventful for Ryoka, that was. Reynold kept his head bowed and shoulders hunched as he and the mysterious [Maid] walked ahead of Ryoka. She could see the [Maid] speaking to Reynold the entire way, and Ryoka was fairly sure what was being said weren’t compliments.

She felt a bit bad for Reynold. But just a bit. Ryoka was grateful for the speed at which both servants walked—they moved fast down the most

crowded of streets. Their attire made them stand out, and Ryoka saw them getting a lot of looks as she followed them.

It was funny. Ryoka smiled as she walked. When the two of Magnolia's servants turned back to look at her, they saw her smiling and staring down at the fat snowflakes swirling down from the sky.

It was a look seldom seen on Ryoka's face. But Ryoka had just realized the silliness of her situation. She was following a [Butler] and a [Maid] down a street in a city that could have come from her world with a few alterations, carrying a Frost Faerie in her belt pouch.

It was just so silly. And sad. That Ryoka could smile made it a bit better.

She stared up at the inn as the [Maid] led them to it. Ryoka ignored the woman as she stepped away from Reynold and practically vanished into the next crowd of Humans.

The Crag Pig was an inn with the head of, well, probably a Crag Pig mounted on the front. This skull was quite, quite big, and had a pair of tusks that curved slightly upwards. They were long, jagged—and branched, like the horns of an antler. Ryoka wondered if that was because they were useful in the Crag Pig's natural habitat, or whether the skull being here was a testament to their qualities.

"Well, I guess I'd better have a chat. Reynold, if you would?"

The [Butler] opened the doors and Ryoka walked in. Her first impression of the inn was that it was definitely *not* as nice as Erin's. The Crag Pig's owner must have thought that the name of his inn excused the dirt, or else the name was a warning.

Still, the room was packed and a fire was taking the chill off. Ryoka looked around and saw a man and a woman waiting the tables, but no [Innkeeper]. She shrugged, found the stairs, and headed towards them.

"Welcome, sir! Let me find you a table. Please—I'll have a seat for you and a hot drink right away!"

To her amusement, Ryoka saw a big man—a former adventurer perhaps—hurry out of the kitchen and accost Reynold as he tried to follow her. The owner of the inn had scars all over his arms, and he was trying to usher the protesting Reynold into a seat.

There were flaws with being impeccably dressed after all. Not that Reynold's attire would be so dashing if he sat down in one of the chairs in this inn. Ryoka shook her head as she went up the stairs two at a time.

"Now, where's Laken...? Ah."

It was the work of five seconds to find Laken's room. Not because the door was open or Ryoka spotted anyone coming out; there was simply only one room that could conceivably hold someone of Durene's size. It was probably the master suite.

Ryoka headed towards the door and knocked twice.

"Laken? It's me, Ryoka Griffin."

Someone had been talking inside the room. When Ryoka knocked, the voice stopped abruptly. Ryoka listened for sounds of movement, but heard none.

It was a surprise, then, when the door opened and Ryoka saw Durene staring down at her. For such a big girl, Durene could move quite silently.

"Hi. Durene, right? Is Laken inside? I want to talk with him."

"He's inside."

The young woman nodded and tried to walk inside. But a very thick, grey-skinned arm shot out to block her. Ryoka looked up and saw Durene staring down at her.

"Please move. I'm just going to talk to him."

"You ran away earlier. And you haven't said why you're here."

"Yeah. I had something to do."

Ryoka stared up at Durene. The half-Troll girl was hostile, but...Ryoka thought it was more than just wariness around Ryoka.

"I don't trust you."

"Okay."

Possessiveness, that was it. Ryoka remembered how Durene hovered around Laken. She was treating him like...

A few thoughts flashed through Ryoka's mind. Dependency? Probably. She could imagine what might occur when Laken had come to this world. Blind guy meets half-Troll. A reverse case of Beauty and the Beast. But the beast is actually a girl who was afraid of losing the one person who didn't fear her.

"I'm not your enemy. And I'm not going to do anything to Laken. I just want to talk with him."

"Why?"

Ryoka bit her tongue. Durene's tone told her there was no good answer she could give. She knew that because it was the exact same tone of voice she used to use when talking with her father.

"Look, is Laken in there? Laken—"

“He’s sleeping. You can come back later.”

Durene shifted so more of her body was in the way. Ryoka stared up at her. Well, there were several ways this could go.

“Can you wake him up? I need to talk to him now. I’m sorry if that’s a problem, but it’s urgent.”

“No. He’s tired. You can come back later. If you try to come in, I’ll stop you.”

One of Durene’s hands closed. Ryoka eyed it and put her hands on her belt. She knew Ivolethe was sitting in her belt pouch, but it wasn’t that Ryoka was reaching for. At her belt, there were several potions Octavia had given her. Ryoka put her fingers on one of them, second from the right.

“Look, I understand you’re Laken’s...protector. And girlfriend. I’m not here to do anything to him, but I *need* to talk with him. And you shouldn’t start a fight here.”

“Oh yeah? Why not? I could stop you.”

“No, you couldn’t.”

Ryoka sighed. She yanked the potion free from her belt in one move. Durene blinked down at it. Ryoka put her thumb on the cork—

And handed it to Durene.

“Here.”

The huge girl stared dumbfounded at the potion. She peered at Ryoka suspiciously.

“What’s this?”

“A pepper potion. Toss it at your opponent and they’ll go blind. Be careful—if it gets in your eyes you’ll be screaming about it all day. If you’re going to go around picking fights, at least get some magical items and a weapon.”

Durene looked uneasy as she held the potion.

“Were you going to hit me with this?”

“No, I’d use a spell and blind you first and *then* I’d hit you with the potion. Actually, I’d probably just blow up this entire corridor and run downstairs while everything burns down.”

Ryoka had two bags of compressed flour and the blaze potions. She didn’t know if it would actually hurt Durene that badly; she had a feeling that would only piss the girl off. But it made Durene stop and think.

“Keep the potion. You’ll probably need it. If it’s you—you could probably pour it on your hands and just punch people in the face. Not that

they're likely to get up after you hit them, but it's a thought. Just don't touch your eyes until after you've washed them thoroughly—with soap. Can I talk to Laken now?"

Durene just stared at Ryoka. She hesitated, looked down at the potion with bits of red pepper floating in it, and over her shoulder.

"Wait here. I'll wake him up."

Ryoka waited patiently. She heard Reynold come up the stairs—the [Butler] looked as though he'd had to tear himself physically away from the innkeeper.

A few voices muttered inside, and then the door opened. Durene let Ryoka walk in, but blocked Reynold.

"Ryoka can talk. Everyone else stays outside."

Reynold protested, but Ryoka didn't hear his conversation with Durene. The first thing she saw when entering Laken's room made her stop in place. Because she'd seen Frostwing.

The baby bird was snoozing on a little platform made into a nest for him. He was surrounded by a warm blanket, and his 'nest' was more ripped-up shreds of fabric than actual cloth. It was also stained quite badly with his droppings. But the bird shone in Ryoka's gaze.

"Wow."

He looked like an eagle. Well, vaguely like an eagle. Ryoka had never studied bird species, but she knew only one kind of bird grew that big.

No—if size was the comparison, than Frostwing was more like an albatross than an eagle. Because he was clearly young, still a nestling, but he was almost the size of a full-grown chicken already.

And he was blue. That was the important thing. Frostwing's feathers glittered in the light as he opened and flapped his wings, protesting this stranger's intrusion into his home. Ryoka saw each feather glittering like a jewel; they had a subtle gradient that made the dark oxford blue of the inner part of each feather fade to a brilliant sky blue on the tips.

A blue bird. But not any bird. For a second, Ryoka was lost to the world. She was in another place, sitting on the balcony in her home, ten years old, holding a Gameboy and playing the video game that had defined her life at that time—

"Ryoka? Is that you?"

She looked up. Laken was sitting on the large bed, yawning and turning his head around the room. A young man was standing by his side, offering

him assistance that Laken clearly didn't need.

Laken, and...Gamel, was it?

"I'm here, Laken."

Ryoka approached the bed. That was a bad move. She was still staring at Frostwing—too long. The bird may have been a child, but it had instincts that made it wary of anything that stared at it.

Frostwing *shrieked* his displeasure. Durene backed away, covering her ears as Gamel tried unsuccessfully to sooth the agitated young bird. Ryoka just stared as Frostwing spread his wings, shedding brilliant blue feathers onto the ground.

"Oh for the love of—here!"

Laken turned, frowning, and fumbled his way towards Frostwing. He reached out and the bird shut up as one of his hands found a piece of dried meat and offered it to the bird.

"Shh, Frostwing. Shut up. There's a good bird."

Laken stroked the crest on Frostwing's head and the bird stopped shrieking. It tore greedily at the bit of meat and Laken turned to Ryoka, looking sheepish.

"Sorry. Pet bird. I've had to apologize to the innkeeper already. At least he wasn't doing this in the middle of the night this time. It *is* daytime, right?"

"That's right. I'm here to talk some more. Sorry about dropping in unexpectedly."

"No it's no problem—"

Laken rubbed at his face. He looked tired.

"Ah...Gamel?"

"Yes, sir?"

"Can you...get me something to drink? And a snack, maybe? Durene, did I hear someone else was here?"

"Yes. It's that [Butler]. Reynold."

"Mister Laken, I apologize for the intrusion. But—"

"Yes, yes. Okay, Gamel, I'll handle Frostwing. He doesn't need food—he just needs to take another nap. Durene, please guard the door? I think I need to talk to Ryoka. Alone."

"Okay, Laken."

There was something about Laken. When he spoke, things got done. Ryoka watched the protesting Reynold get slowly pushed out the door. She

waved at him before Durene closed the door. Laken sat on the edge of his bed, slowly petting Frostwing as the bird rubbed its head against his palm.

“You have a bird.”

“Yes. Ryoka, meet Frostwing. Frostwing—don’t nip my fingers.”

Ryoka stared at Frostwing. Her eyes turned back to Laken.

“You have a bird. It’s blue.”

He frowned.

“Yes—yes I do. I found Frostwing near Durene’s cottage. I think his mother died of starvation or—something else. I took Frostwing in. I actually have a class from raising him. [Beast Tamer].”

“Oh?”

Ryoka stared at Frostwing. She felt like she had to repeat herself.

“It’s blue. I—excuse me.”

She reached for her pocket as Laken frowned. She knew it was stupid, but Ryoka had to do this. She pulled her iPhone out of her pocket and turned it on.

Laken was still a bit bleary from waking up, but he was trying to get his thoughts together quickly. Ryoka was here. That was good. He had so many questions he wanted to ask her, but he had to be careful, didn’t he? He wasn’t sure of her. Not yet. But she was *from his world*. Or—and here his cautious self spoke up—she was pretending to be. Could this all be a ploy? Her knowing German meant someone had come from another world, but maybe she was using a Skill? Was that possible?

Ryoka wasn’t saying much. She seemed to be fixated on Frostwing. Was it really that special that he was blue? Laken tried to remember if there were other blue birds back home. Obviously he’d never seen any, but...blue birds, what about them? What made Frostwing stand out that much?

Then he heard something. It was faint, muffled, and familiar. Laken frowned.

“Ryoka? Are you there?”

No response. Laken hesitated, and then leaned towards the source of the muted music. His eyes widened.

“Is that...is that the Pokemon theme song?”

Ryoka pulled the earbuds out.

“No.”

“It *is*!”

Laken smiled and laughed.

“You’re a Pokemon fan!”

“I was. Once. A long time ago.”

Ryoka shifted, coughed. Laken couldn’t see, but she’d turned bright red. Laken grinned.

“Does Frostwing remind you of a Pokemon that much?”

“Yeah. He looks like Articuno, you know?”

“That’s a Pokemon?”

“A legendary. One of the legendary birds from the original one hundred and fifty.”

“Ah. I never actually played Pokemon growing up. Sort of hard when you can’t see anything.”

“Oh. Right.”

Ryoka coughed again, clearly embarrassed. Laken was smiling so hard it hurt. For just a few moments, he felt like he was back home, back in his world.

“You’re a fan. I had no idea. Did you play that new thing coming out? Pokemon Go?”

“I uh, a bit. It was a long time ago. Or it feels like it. I...was teleported here a few days after I downloaded the app, actually.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

The conversation fell flat in an instant. Ryoka shifted as she glanced at Frostwing again. Laken blinked and gestured with his other hand.

“I’m so sorry. Please, sit. I don’t know where the chair is, but I’m assured we have at least two.”

“I see it.”

Ryoka dragged the chair over as Laken tried to make Frostwing go to sleep. He thought it worked, or at least, the bird had given up moving. He turned and sat cross-legged on his bed as he faced in Ryoka’s direction.

“I think Durene gave you some trouble as I was sleeping. Is that right?”

“Just a bit. She’s protective of you.”

Laken smiled wryly.

“She is. Thank you for not hitting her with that potion.”

Ryoka shrugged, and then remembered Laken couldn't see any of her gestures.

"It's nothing. Good thing we didn't meet a month or two ago or I'd have gotten my head pushed through a wall."

"Really?"

"I picked a fight with a Minotaur one time. That was one of the dumber things I've ever done."

"Minotaurs exist in this world?"

"Yup. They're touchy and prideful. And fairly rude, but they are honorable."

"Fascinating. I've heard this continent has mainly...Gnolls, is it? And Drakes?"

"They inhabit the southern parts, yes. Invisil is sort of an exception—it's a major city so a lot of races come here. But you'll generally find only Humans in the north."

"I understand. Durene's village is totally Human save for her."

"Hm."

The two sat in silence for another second. Ryoka sat still in her chair; Laken wiggled around, wondering if there was something that he was sitting on. A fork, maybe? Whatever it was, it was poking into his butt.

Unnoticed by the two of them, a third being was present in the room, listening. Ivolethe sat in Ryoka's pouch, listening carefully. The Frost Faerie considered that her sisters would have hated the conversation between Ryoka and Laken. It wasn't a thing of majesty or destiny. But it was important.

"I guess we should talk."

"Yes, I guess we should."

The boy and girl sat across from each other. They were old, but still young by the way the faerie reckoned such things. They had gone through sorrows, gone through trials. But they were still young. So young.

It was the girl who spoke first. She hesitated as she chewed at a lip, glancing towards the closed doors. Durene and Gamel stood behind it, but Ryoka knew the danger wasn't something she could see.

"It's complicated, you know? I want to say what's on my mind but—"

"You did mention. Watchers and such."

"Yeah. But if we assume we lost them or they can't hear us—which I don't—I'm fairly certain someone's using magic to listen in."

Laken raised his eyebrows calmly.

“Well, it’s not like we have anything to hide.”

“Hah.”

“Okay, fine. But how are you proposing we solve this problem? I have something I need to say which will clarify things.”

“I’m in the same boat. I can say that I have a friend—Erin Solstice who’s from our world straight off, but the rest is harder.”

“Someone else? You mentioned that—what’s she like?”

“Age wise? She’s twenty. Besides that, she’s...a normal girl. Sort of. She’s American, like me.”

“Interesting. I’m twenty-four. Not American. Can I assume you’re around that age?”

“Twenty one. You don’t look that old. You’re part German. Is there another half?”

Laken smiled.

“My mom’s German, but she married my dad in France. I’ve grown up all over Europe, though. As to my face—I’m told I have a youthful complexion.”

Ryoka had to smile. She glanced at the door and frowned.

“Good to know. I don’t think any of this is too bad to mention, but the rest...damn, I don’t know. Erin would probably come up with some special way of figuring this out. Flush out the spies with a crazy scheme and dispel the enchantments with an insane trick or just luck.”

“She sounds quite interesting.”

“She’s an [Innkeeper]. Look, I’m getting annoyed. Maybe we should just go for broke. What do you think? I doubt anyone knows German.”

“Wahrscheinlich. But can *you* speak it? I don’t want to be rude, but your pronunciation—”

“I know. But I’ve got a dictionary-encyclopedia. It’s an app—I might have to ask for spelling, but I can translate short sentences.”

“That’s...amazingly useful. In that case, translate this. Ich bin ein [Kaiser].”

It took Ryoka only a second to figure out what Laken had said. She didn’t need to use her iPhone. Instead, she dropped it. She fumbled around on the ground, heart beating wildly. When she sat back up she stared at Laken’s face.

“You’re lying.”

“I’m not. I know it’s surprising, but it’s true. What about you?”

“I don’t have a class. I’m a Runner without the class. But you—get out.”

“It’s true!”

Laken smiled. He had no way of seeing Ryoka’s face, but her tone made her feelings clear.

“No, seriously, get out. Run away as far as you can. Do you have any idea how *bad* that is?”

“Bad? Why? Because of your—your Daenerys-like friend?”

“Yes! Not just her—Ivolethe!”

Ryoka shouted the faerie’s name. Laken jumped, and then gaped as the faerie floated upwards and spoke.

“What do ye want, Ryoka?”

“Go downstairs and flush out the spies. Please? And if there are enchantments, dispel them. Please. This is important.”

The faerie considered the request. Then she reluctantly nodded.

“I shall bring havoc! From the outside.”

She flew out the window as Laken tried to find words.

“Was that—a *Frost Faerie*?”

“You’ve met them?”

“Yes! Hell, I *knighted* a few of them. But they helped save Durene’s cottage from an avalanche—or caused it and spared her home. I’m not sure of which.”

“Well, I’m friends with one. Look, sit down. I’ll explain as much as I can—but the Frost Faeries probably didn’t cause the avalanche. They don’t kill, although they do pull horrible pranks.”

Ryoka and Laken sat down as, below them, they heard confused shouting. Ivolethe’s laughter was drowned out as she buzzed by the inn outside, but Ryoka could just imagine her hurling snow and ice into the building.

“Okay, let me begin from the start. The first thing you need to know is that I got here a few months ago. I’d say around...September? A while back. But Erin arrived before me. We don’t know how we got here, but I

know there are other people in this world. I also know that not a lot of people know we exist. That woman I told you about—Lady Magnolia Reinhart. She employs Reynold and a bunch of other servants, and she's one of the most powerful people on the continent..."

Laken listened intently as Ryoka whispered to him amid the sounds of the inn clearing out. He turned to tell Durene everything was fine when she told him the bottom half of the inn was covered with snow, but he mainly just listened as Ryoka gave him an abridged version of what had happened when she entered this world.

And then it was his turn. Ryoka didn't just listen—she had her iPhone held in her lap, recording Laken's every word as he spoke. She didn't mention this fact, and neither did Laken or Ryoka ever mention certain key words aloud.

Words like [Emperor], gunpowder, iPhone, dragon, or a thousand other words from home. Ryoka was glad that Laken understood, and he picked up what she feared from what Ryoka never said.

"It sounds like you've had a rough time without a class. I can't say I understand that bit."

"I don't like conformity."

"You think that's an issue—wait. I think I get it. Game system, right? But is there a puppet master?"

"Probably, yes."

"Oh, really? How do you know?"

Laken sat forwards. Ryoka hesitated, and then leaned forwards as well. Though she knew Reynold and the other spies in the building were probably gone, she whispered to him in German.

"Ein Gott...lebt."

A slow frown was her only reply. Laken sat back carefully.

"How?"

"I don't know. But I talked with someone who assures me it's true. And I believe him."

"In that case—that *is* concerning. But still, as far as I understand it, the system is essential. You can't fight a...a monster without Skills."

"Yeah. But do we lose anything if we have a class?"

Laken's voice was thoughtful.

"I don't know. And honestly, I'm not sure I'd be willing to try and find out, if it were me. But if you want to be the test subject...I'm glad. It's good

to have someone who might be impartial. Especially if what you say is true.”

“I don’t know if they’re connected, but it seems so.”

“Oh, I agree. But really...alive?”

“Yes. And apparently talking about them gives them strength.”

Laken shivered.

“That’s horrific. Terrifying. But it sounds like this—person—isn’t too active?”

“No. I shouldn’t say lebt. More like...hold on. Schlafen. Aufwachen.”

“Ah.”

It was as if he’d taken a drink of water after being dehydrated. Laken felt everything snap more into place.

“I think I get it. Or at least, I have a hypothesis.”

“So do I. Either way? It’s bad news.”

“But from what you say, it doesn’t seem like that’s the reason we’re here. It’s probably a spell?”

“Someone said that there was a summoning spell. In Rhir.”

“Something to look into. I guess.”

Laken frowned and scrubbed at his hair.

“This is all so *complex*! How are we supposed to figure this out? It’s not as if we can just ask, and we don’t have people we can trust to find out. I don’t, at any rate. You have your [Lady] friend, but I don’t trust her further than I can throw her either.”

“Yeah, I’m not too keen on asking. But those angry ant people I told you about? Their entire race is scared spitless of this one person.”

Ryoka chewed her lip, feeling the same urgent panic rising in her chest when she thought about—

A God. A real God, sleeping under the earth.

She expected Laken to share at least a bit of her concern. But the blind man refused to panic.

“I get the issue. But they’re on another continent, right? There’s not much we can do right now—except spread the word, I guess, and find someone who can do something.”

“So you’re saying we don’t even think about it?”

It was impossible to glare at a blind man successfully. Laken smiled.

“Look, if we’re talking about this—person as a threat, then all we need is a devil, right? Anyone tried blood summoning, chanting in Latin, or

hooded robes? Or we could get a few angry atheists. Who knows? It could work.”

Ryoka stared at Laken and then burst out laughing.

“You cocky bastard.”

He raised his hands, smiling and laughing with her.

“Hey, it’s a problem. But it’s not immediate, is it? If I panicked over all of the big things, I’d never get to sleep at night.”

“Fine. I get it. Back to you, then. You’re in a bind. Assuming no one catches wind of what you do, you’re going to need help for that village of yours.”

Laken nodded. He wove his fingers together and tightened his grip.

“I think we’ve got food and protection, but if you know anything about...anything, I’d love to have some help.”

Ryoka had to confess her knowledge was limited.

“I’ve got some information, but it’s all scattered. Ruling a village—good luck. Other than that, technology’s tricky. I’m not giving you the recipe for...well, firearms.”

“Perish the thought.”

“—And I can’t tell you how to make anything too useful. Steam engines, light bulbs...not exactly stuff your village needs right now.”

“No.”

Ryoka frowned as she tapped a finger on her leg, letting it bounce against the floorboards. Laken found the sound slightly annoying, but he waited patiently for Ryoka to finish thinking.

“Greenhouses might help. If you can get sheets of glass for the roof, you can build the rest of the structure out of other materials. That would extend your growing season—let you get a head start on growing.”

“Really?”

“There’s glass in this world. If you can get panes, or one large sheet—could be tricky, could be worth it. I see some parchment over there. I’ll use that, okay?”

“Feel free.”

Laken heard Ryoka rustling about and then her fiddling with the inkpot.

“Let me do a sketch. It’s all about keeping the heat in, more than letting it out—on that note, what about agricultural implements? I’d have to do more thinking, but the heavy plough is a good invention to check on.”

“I’m familiar with a plough—sort of. What’s the heavy one do?”

“It’s really just a way to make it better. You have wheels and...nah, it’s really just the wheels that change it. It lets a farmer move faster, reduces the burden, et cetera. See?”

“No, I don’t. But go ahead.”

He heard a chuckle.

“Okay...I’m drawing a diagram, but just ask whether the [Farmers] in your village use wheels on their ploughs. I’ll write down what I know about crop rotation too—”

They continued in that vein for a few more minutes. Then Laken switched the issue over to protection.

“I don’t think a palisade’s going to stop a monster, do you?”

“It’s worth a shot. A wall would be better.”

Ryoka raised her eyebrows as she sketched out the cross section of a wall. Laken had another thought.

“If we’re talking about walls, then what about trebuchets? You wouldn’t happen to know—”

“Hah. If you’re fighting monsters the size of castles, maybe. But they’re a pain in the ass to aim. Just build a catapult; you can probably figure out how. Actually, now that I think of it...a ballista might be easier than an onager.”

“Okay? What’s an onager?”

“That’s a catapult. The classic kind that hurls things like a spoon.”

“Oh. Yes, I could see that being useful.”

“I’ll write down how to make both for you.”

“And that’s not classified? I thought we were trying to reduce the spread of dangerous weapons.”

“I did my research. They’re already in use. The Drakes have them on some of their city walls, and they’re used around the world. The trick is that most people can’t build them. You have to have the [Engineer] class to build one.”

“Ah. No one bothers to learn. They just use a class.”

“Yep. But you can probably whip one together...just be careful with the tension on the rope. Build some prototypes and test them—carefully. Look, I’ll write this down and you can have someone read it. I’m sure your villagers can find some decent rope to use.”

“I’m sure they’ve got something. Okay, how about barns?”

“Barns?”

“Do you have a better way of building them, or something?”

“Good point. I can definitely tell you how to make a log wall...that’s just cutting the logs right. Uh...I don’t know about other building techniques. Let me get back to you on that. Shame there’s no metalworking industry or you could try mass-producing things like ring-shank nails...”

“You’re losing me here.”

Ryoka smiled as she bent over the parchment. She was running out of room. But surprisingly, she was enjoying her conversation with Laken. Did she trust him? A bit. A little bit.

An [Emperor]. She couldn’t imagine it. But he sat like one, or—perhaps the beginnings of one. She saw that now.

Emperor Norton. She remembered that story! The crazy guy who declared himself the Emperor of the United States. People might remember that story, but how many would think to do it here?

Not many. Ryoka had never dreamed of that. And it wasn’t just that. Could anyone really just become an [Emperor] by willing it? No. You had to have something else, or anyone could be an [Emperor], right? You had to have...

“The arrogance of a God.”

“Excuse me?”

“Nothing. What was I saying?”

Ryoka went to dip her quill in the inkpot. She wished she had a pen. As she did, she glanced at the window, still ajar. She wondered when Ivolethe would come back—

And she was there. Ivolethe. She was hovering outside the window, watching Ryoka and Laken talk. Just watching. Ryoka froze, quill dripping blobs of ink.

There was something about the way the Frost Faerie stared at her. Something...

She was watching. Waiting. Ryoka felt a chill.

“Ryoka? Is something wrong?”

“I—I don’t know. I think there might be—”

How could she explain it to Laken? Ryoka was grasping at words, when she saw something move in front of her.

It was on the table she’d pulled up to write on. Her iPhone, still recording every word Laken spoke, began to vibrate. It shuddered on the

wood surface a microsecond before Ryoka heard the familiar, annoying jangle of her ringtone.

Someone was calling her. Ryoka felt her breath catch in her chest.

“Is that—”

Laken reached for the iPhone, but Ryoka was faster. She saw the familiar calling screen, but there was nothing listed under the caller’s phone number, only the option to accept or decline.

“It’s my iPhone. I’m getting a call—”

“From who?”

“It has to be [BlackMage]!”

“Who?”

“The person who—I’m answering it.”

Laken held his breath as Ryoka gingerly tapped the glowing green phone symbol. Instantly, she heard a voice.

“—he’s not answering. Maybe try ag—hello? Hello? Can you hear me?”

Ryoka traded glances with Laken. He missed. Ryoka tilted her iPhone’s speaker towards her mouth cautiously.

“I can hear you. Who is this?”

“Oh my god. Is this—are you [batman]? [batman]’s a *girl*?”

It was a young man’s voice, excited, with the touches of...an English accent? Yes, it definitely wasn’t American. Ryoka carefully put the call on speaker phone as she and Laken crowded around her device. She put a finger to his lips and he nodded.

“This is great! I’ve tried calling you before and you didn’t pick up. Hi there! This is [BlackMage]! From the chat? Do you remember me? Well, I was calling you to—”

“Fuck you.”

Ryoka heard [BlackMage] pause. She saw Laken glance at her oddly, but she didn’t care. Anxiety had become irritation and anger in a second.

“What?”

“Go fuck yourself. Do you know how *stupid* it is to call someone like this? What would have happened if I were in a dungeon, or trying to hide from a monster?”

“I—”

“You have *compromised* my damn phone! You know that asshole was trying to find out locations! Do you think he’s really not trying to track us

down right now? I'd bet anything that this kind of call can be traced. Now people know exactly where you and I are."

"Hold on! We don't *know* anyone's tracking this call. I'm with a bunch of [Mages] and they say—"

"Screw what they say. This is dangerous. Didn't you get that from your call?"

"That's *why* I'm calling you!"

The young man on the other end of the line was getting angry. He spoke quickly before Ryoka could insult him again.

"We—the mages of Wistram and I—are trying to find people across the world! I've called a bunch of people and we're trying to bring them here. To Wistram!"

"That is the *stupidest*—how do you know you're not revealing their locations?"

"We—we're using magic in secret."

"Oh? Well, that makes me feel better."

"Look, if you're going to be an asshole about this, I can hang up."

"No, it's too late now."

Ryoka tried to calm herself down. She took a deep breath.

"Okay, why *are* you calling? To invite me to Wistram?"

"Yes. We can send help. We can have money sent—or get in touch with a local [Mage] affiliated with us who can help you reach the isle. But I contacted *you* first because you managed to uncover that fake wanker—[Kent Scott] and warn everyone. Do you know who he is?"

"No. I have no idea. But I was suspicious from the start. Forget [Kent Scott]. How do I know I can trust you, or anyone?"

"I—look, you're being fairly suspicious of me, don't you think? I'm calling you—"

"And I don't *trust* people who call me out of the blue. How can we prove that these people at Wistram are trustworthy?"

"We can't."

Ryoka heard [BlackMage] gasp on the other end of the line. Laken took the iPhone from her and spoke into it. She stared at him, wanting to signal him, but it was impossible to do visually. She tapped his hand with a finger—he waved his hand at her and then gave her a thumbs up.

"Excuse me? Who is this?"

"Call me L. I'm from our world as well. I just met [batman]."

Laken kept his voice low as he spoke into the receiver. He was smiling as if he was *enjoying* his conversation with the flustered [BlackMage].

“Wow! You’ve met someone else? Where are you? Do you need help? What’s your class—I forgot to mention we’re keeping a list—”

“My class is secret. So is my location. If you can trace this phone call, well, good luck searching the continent. I’m sorry to be so secretive, but neither [batman] nor I are able to trust you, or Wistram at this point in time.”

“Why? Hey, we’re acting in good faith here—”

“Just think about it.”

Laken leaned back on the bed as he spoke carefully, choosing each word with deliberation.

“You say you want to help us. But how can we be sure that’s the case? Putting aside the reputation of Wistram, we can’t tell if you’re calling from there. You could be impersonating them—we have no way to tell. Telling you our location is dangerous, especially on what could be an unsecured call like this. You understand that, right?”

“I—I suppose I do. But how am I supposed to convince you I’m trustworthy?”

“That’s impossible at this moment. There’s no one in Wistram who could convince us, and a truth spell can’t be used. However...there is a way to tell everyone where to go and not reveal confidential information.”

“Really? How?”

Laken could feel Ryoka’s eyes on him, even if he couldn’t see her. He smiled.

“Don’t call anyone. But have Wistram—the Isle of Mages, right? Have them send out a proclamation, a message to every corner of the world. Something simple. Something anyone from our world could understand.”

“Oh!”

Ryoka nodded as she realized what Laken was saying. That could work. She spoke into the receiver.

“Say something like...‘To all the millennials, the Americans and citizens of the European Union and’—no, wait. That’s not right. Instead... send something in every language you can think of. One word. Come home. 家に帰る.”

“Nach Hause zurückkehren.”

“Ven a Casa. In every language you can think of. Understand?”

“I see!”

“But don’t stop there.”

Laken angled the iPhone towards his mouth and spoke urgently.

“Set it up so that anyone affiliated with Wistram will help someone from our world. But have them ask for confirmation. Something only someone from our world would know. Easy things, for every culture.”

“Like if you’re American—who’s the current president? Actually—shit. Be prepared for different answers. Someone might say Obama and not know who the current president is.”

“Good point! And some people might not speak English.”

“Hold on, let me write all this down!”

[BlackMage] was scrambling to keep up. Laken and Ryoka heard other voices, muffled in the background. She nudged him and he squeezed her arm. There were other people listening to the call.

“Okay, we can do that. Thanks for the advice!”

“No problem. Just be sure you know what you’re doing.”

“...How do you mean?”

Laken paused.

“If you do this, you’ll paint a target on your chest for the world to see. Understand—some people who’ve come to this world will not be friends. Just think about it. Assuming everyone who’s arrived is around the same age—you could get anyone from any part of the world. What if you got a radical extremist from ISIS?”

“Or someone from North Korea. Or a kid in a gang, a convicted criminal.”

“...I hadn’t thought of that.”

“Be careful. If everyone’s heading to Wistram, then the real battle becomes getting them there safely...and figuring out who’s trustworthy.”

“We can use spells for that. And Wistram is almost impossible to take by force. There are Golems here, Archmages...”

“If it’s so safe, we’ll find our way there. Eventually. But don’t call us again, understand? If you have to contact us—do it by chat.”

“I understand. And I will...I’ll have to tell the other mages about this, and see what they think.”

“Good. In that case, we’ll end the call.”

“Huh? But there’s so much we have to discuss!”

Laken felt a warning tug on his hand.

“Unfortunately, we can’t be sure who’s listening in. Continuing this phone call is too risky. Contact [batman] later if you have to. Try to find a securer means of communicating. Until then.”

“Wai—”

Laken hung up the phone. He handed it to Ryoka and breathed out slowly. His hand was shaking. So was hers as she took it.

“Wow. That was...unexpected.”

Ryoka glanced sideways and saw Ivolethe flying away from the window.

“...Yeah. Good idea, by the way. That was a great thought.”

“It was spur-of-the-moment. But maybe this way word will spread and people won’t get kidnapped. You think it’s a possibility?”

Ryoka shrugged. She wasn’t sure herself.

“There was someone who tried to figure out where we were. Better safe than sorry.”

“Yeah. And one last thing. I didn’t mention it to [BlackMage], but aside from other nations, other factions trying to attack Wistram...if we go there, we’d better have friends. Allies. So we can deal with the mages on equal terms.”

“Can’t trust them, can’t trust anyone, right?”

“Right. Well, some people will be trustworthy, but—”

“How do you find them?”

They sat in silence for a moment, hearts beating. Ryoka looked at Laken and smirked.

“L, huh? Nice reference.”

“What? I’m sorry, did I accidentally do something?”

She paused.

“Never mind. It’s a reference to a popular—it’s fine.”

Laken spread his hands.

“Okay. What now? That was dramatic. And scary. I may have wet the bed. Where do we go from here?”

Ryoka shrugged.

“I don’t know. I guess you go back to your village and...do your thing. Gather strength, or something. I go back and tell Erin—and we meet again.”

“Just like that?”

“I guess so. Look, I want to help, but I have to go back. It’s Christmas, and Erin told me to get back in time for the party. And I have...other things

to do there as well.”

“Christmas! My God, I’d forgotten!”

Laken slapped a hand to his forehead.

“I should celebrate that with Durene and the villagers! That would be—I wonder if I can get the Merchant’s Guild to find me a bunch of presents?”

“They’d wrap them for you, I bet. Look, I hate to just run, but I don’t know what else I can do. Erin lives so far away, and I never come up here. I can try and return now and then, but it might be we have to communicate by [Message] spell for the moment.”

Laken nodded.

“We can talk in code—or German, I suppose. I’ll probably be out of touch for…I don’t know how long.”

“We have our own places to be, don’t we?”

“It’s odd, but yes. I have a home now. A…”

An empire. Laken didn’t say it out loud. Ryoka stared at him, and wondered. He was likeable, smart, and he cared about people. But he was an [Emperor]. What would come from that?

They didn’t speak much about the future after that. Ryoka drew a bit more on the parchment, and discussed water mills with Laken. He offered her tips on dealing with Frost Faeries, and she convinced him to make Ivolethe an archduchess.

And then for an hour they laughed and talked about home. Laken told Ryoka about what he did for a living—he was ostensibly unemployed since his parents were fairly rich, but he worked with other people with disabilities and led blind tours as well. She told him about Erin and her own backstory. Mainly anecdotes of her run-ins with authority.

“An American rebel, huh? Tell me you ride a motorcycle and I’ll ask for an autograph.”

And then Durene knocked on the door, and Frostwing woke up, and the moment ended. Ryoka stood up, and Laken did too as he tapped his bird on the beak.

“Hush, Frostwing. Say goodbye to Ryoka. She’s got to go.”

“I’ll be in the city until tomorrow, I think. I have to do something quick. Hell, I might not leave until tomorrow night. You can find me at Magnolia Reinhart’s mansion…it might be better if you wait until I come into the city. I’ll find you tomorrow, how about that?”

“Sounds good. Durene? Ryoka’s going to go, but we have a lot to talk about. Can you call Gamel up?”

Ryoka paused next to Laken.

“You’re going to tell her everything?”

“I trust her. And the less secrets there are in this world, the better.”

She hesitated.

“I wish I could be more like you. But I can’t.”

He made a face.

“I think you’re fine the way you are, Miss Ryoka Griffin. Someone needs to be the cynical bastard who watches our backs.”

She laughed.

“I can do that. Good luck. See you later.”

And then she was gone. Laken sat back on his bed, and lay on his back as Durene came back into the room with Gamel. He didn’t look up as Durene sat carefully on the bed and everything tilted towards her.

“Durene?”

“Yes, Laken?”

“Where’s Wistram?”

Ryoka endured Reynold’s sniffing and very hostile remarks as she walked down the street. The snow was falling thickly around them, but that didn’t muffle his acidic comments.

“Look, I’m sorry. I didn’t know Ivolethe would go that far. But I did warn you.”

“I’m simply doing my job, Miss Ryoka.”

“Yeah, well, take it up with Magnolia. Or Ressa.”

“I believe I’d rather follow you, Miss.”

“It’s your funeral. Look, it’s one last trip and then we can go home and you can sit in front of a fire.”

“Where to, Miss?”

“Back to Hedault. I have to do something.”

Reynold’s eyebrows rose, but Ryoka didn’t elaborate.

If Hedault was surprised to see Ryoka back so soon, he opened the door readily enough.

“Why have you returned?”

“I’m going to sell you the wand.”

It was refreshing not to have to beat around the bush with him. Ryoka saw Hedault’s eyebrows rise, but the [Enchanter] didn’t miss a beat.

“I can have the gold pieces prepared for you within the hour. I will also provide a second bag of holding as the first will not be able to support the weight—”

“Hold on. I’m not looking for gold. You’re going to pay me something else. Something more.”

Hedault paused. He stared at Ryoka, and then at Reynold, whose jaw was fully open.

“My price is final, and calculated on the wand’s probable value. I will not change it.”

“Don’t give me that.”

Ryoka sighed as she found a seat in the [Enchanter]’s living room and sank into it. He stared at her as she put her feet up. She felt *exhausted*. Ryoka stared at him.

“Well? Are you going to sit?”

He did, slowly.

“You seem confident that I will agree to whatever you ask.”

“Yeah, well, that’s because I know what’s inside that wand.”

Hedault paused. Reynold scrambled for a quill and inkpot. The [Enchanter] stared hard at Ryoka, but didn’t call her a liar or scoff. He just asked one question.

“How?”

Ryoka patted her belt pouch.

“Ivolethe? Want to come out? I’m sure Hedault has some snacks for you.”

The Frost Faerie flew out of Ryoka’s belt pouch. Hedault’s eyebrows shot up and Reynold instinctively retreated to one corner of the room as Ivolethe gazed around the room, grinning with her pointed teeth.

Ryoka smiled at Hedault and nodded to Ivolethe.

“You want to know how I know? My friend told me. She’s a Frost Faerie. A Winter Sprite. She can see magic and she’s lived longer than everyone in this city put together. She told me what was put in the wand’s core.”

“I see. A Winter Sprite. Intriguing.”

Hedault glanced towards one of the doors and crooked a finger in his lap. Ryoka blinked as a saucer filled with dried prunes flew over to the table and settled down on it. Ivolethe made a noise of pleasure and began attacking the dried fruit, eating far more than her stomach should have been able to contain.

“If you know the contents of the wand, why offer it to me? Unless the value is lower than my estimation?”

“It’s not. In fact, it’s probably higher. But that’s why you’re going to pay me more. Not just for the wand itself, but for knowing what’s inside.”

“And why should I do that?”

Hedault crossed his arms. Ryoka grinned at that. The mage’s face hadn’t changed, but his folded arms spoke volumes about how much she was getting to him. She gestured expansively at the wand, which Hedault had brought out and put on the coffee table in front of them.

“Just think about it. You’ll never know what was inside, *and* you’ll have to live with the knowledge that it’s being used by some amateur that won’t appreciate it or utilize the wand’s full potential.”

“I ask again. If it *is* so valuable, why not give it to the adventurers who recovered it? They would surely desire it most.”

“I’m sure they would. But neither of my friends could use it to its full potential—it’s not specialized in the right area for them. But you could. And if you couldn’t, I’m sure you could find a buyer for it. Correct me if I’m wrong, but isn’t this the sort of wand an Archmage would want?”

Hedault’s eyes followed the wand. He spoke softly.

“A true [Archmage] would not. But the Archmages of today would certainly use a wand of this caliber if they had nothing finer. And if it is that valuable, I do not believe I have enough funds on hand to pay for it.”

Ryoka nodded, still smiling.

“I know you can’t pay for it. In fact, after talking with Ivolethe, I *know* you probably don’t have enough gold on hand to pay for this wand. But that’s fine, because what I need isn’t gold. It’s artifacts.”

She sat up, and put her hands on the table. She picked up the wand and felt its weight. Ryoka stroked the cold, metallic wood as she looked at Hedault. Part of her was screaming not to do this, but the rest of her was resolute.

“Here’s the deal. If I give this wand to you, you give me enough armor and weapons to outfit four adventurers. That means armor for two of them

—they’re warriors, at least one more sword, maybe a bow, and two wands and a magical robe for the others. Wands, staves...hell, I’ll take a spellbook as well while I’m at it. *And* more magical rings. And two hundred gold pieces.”

He stared at her.

“*Why?* This is not a fair trade. Not for a wand of such value. You may approximate the value with lesser artifacts, but no true adventurer would make such a trade. Why are you doing this on their behalf? If this is an act of self-interest, then I will decline. I will have the answer you have failed to give me. Now.”

His eyes were serious. Ryoka met Hedault’s gaze. She thought he was an honest man. A good man, if he cared about adventurers he’d never met. She nodded abruptly.

“That’s right. It’s not fair. But it’s what my friends need. That’s why you’ll never tell anyone what’s in the wand. It’s why I’ll lie to my friends, though I’m giving them a fortune in artifacts. It’s why I’m selling it. Because this wand is powerful—but it’s not what they *need*.”

“Explain.”

“Come on. You understand, don’t you?”

Ryoka gestured impatiently to the wand she held. She thought she could sense something inside of it. Power. Pure power, untapped, ready to be used. It was so tempting. That was why she couldn’t bring it back.

“They don’t need a wand that will make them a target of every magic-user on the continent. They need armor, weapons—and money. They need the gear to become a Gold-rank team, not a bullseye on their foreheads. So you’re going to give me everything I ask for, and then you’re going to write down in a book, or somewhere important that you’ll never forget. The Horns of Hammerad. That’s who you owe. And someday, you’ll pay that back.”

For a while she thought he wouldn’t accept. Hedault stood up, paced around the room, and stared at the wand. He went to the racks of armor and weapons, inspected them, shook his head, and stared at the wand. He muttered to himself about gold and costs, trying to talk himself out of it. But he kept staring at the wand.

In the end, he sat with a sigh across from Ryoka and she knew she’d won.

“Say I pay your price. What arms and artifacts would you require?”

She shrugged.

“I don’t know what’s best for an adventuring team that’s about to reach Gold-rank. But I bet you do. And I bet you can get everything I want by tomorrow.”

Hedault stared at Ryoka incredulously.

“And you would trust me to make such decisions?”

“I trust that you would be honest. You seem like you’ve been on a level so far. And I can check all the artifacts you give me, and make sure it sounds like a fair trade.”

Again Hedault went around the room. This time he came to a decision faster.

“One condition. Tell me what is inside. And then I will make my choice.”

Ryoka held her breath. She stared at Hedault, and decided that he wasn’t going to budge. So she judged Ivolethe as the faerie sat on the coffee table, still chewing down the much-depleted plate of fruits.

“Ivolethe? Do you mind doing this?”

The faerie looked up. She stared at Hedault, and then dropped the bit of prune she was eating. She stood up, and flew over to the wand resting on the table. And when she stood above it, she wasn’t the somewhat evil, somewhat playful faerie that lived in Ryoka’s belt pouch.

She was something else. Something older that stared down at the wand and touched it with a tiny hand. Ivolethe spoke, and her voice was far away.

“In a forest long gone, there grew a tree. It grew wild, and tall. And free. Ten thousand winters passed as it touched the sky. So tall. So very high. And when it shed the last leaf upon the ground it grew a single bloom. A child, a small one to grow out of the tree’s final doom. But they took it, they stole it, and sealed it away. Here to never grow, here to always stay. For magic thou art, thou small seedling hid. Magic to summon and wield as your owner bids.”

She looked at Hedault, at Ryoka, and Reynold who was staring with wide eyes.

“Ye wish to know what lies within? A seed, foolish mortals. A seed of a tree. A child trapped. The power of the earth, of that which stood through

wind and storm and fire and axe. Unbreakable. For ten thousand years.”

Ryoka felt her skin tingle with goose bumps. There was something about the way Ivolethe spoke, about the way she *existed* that made Ryoka believe every word she said. She stared at the wand and felt her heart ache.

Magic.

“Living magic. That explains everything.”

Hedault slowly picked up the wand, and stared at it. He ran his hands down the surface of it, and held it as if he thought it would break. Then he looked at Ryoka.

She didn’t need to ask. Ryoka smiled, and stood up.

“I need to go back by tomorrow. Can you have everything ready by then?”

“Yes. It will not be enough, but yes.”

Hedault held the wand and looked at Ivolethe. She stared at it with ancient eyes, and then laughed and flew back to the prunes. He looked at Ryoka.

“I will give you what your friends need. But I will write down the debt, Ryoka Griffin. And when they need to call on it, they need only message me.”

She smiled. It was a tired smile, but sincere. It had been a long day, but Ryoka smiled. Her expression was unguarded, and for once, totally genuine. Both Hedault and Reynold felt a tug at their hearts. For different reasons.

“Thank you.”

Then she turned and walked out of Hedault’s home.

It was snowing harder outside. Ryoka stared up at the sky and got a big snowflake in the eye for her trouble. She’d seen worse snow days—

Actually, she wasn’t sure if she had. Ryoka stared ahead and found the snow was falling so thickly that she could barely see ten feet in front of her. Already most of the pedestrians were off of the streets.

“It’s disgusting out here. Let’s go to the mansion!”

For once Reynold was in complete agreement. The two set off at a brisk pace down the street, trying not to slip on the icy pavement.

To Ryoka's unpleasant surprise, she didn't get to go back to Magnolia's mansion with Reynold after that. Instead, she and Reynold were caught by a Street Runner, a Dullahan boy who carried his head on a sling as he ran, as they headed towards the place where he'd parked the carriage.

"Miss Ryoka Griffin? You're wanted at the Runner's Guild now. There's a client to see you!"

"A client? Tell them I'm not interested."

Ryoka wasn't in the mood, but the Street Runner was insistent.

"They want to see you *now*, Miss Ryoka! The [Receptionist] told me to get you or not bother coming back. It's just six blocks away. We can be there in no time if we run. Unless you're too slow and old?"

Ryoka glared at the Dullahan boy who turned his head to smile cockily at her. She knew it was bait, but that didn't stop her from beating him to the Runner's Guild by a solid ten feet. She flipped him off as she walked inside and saw him grin and race away to his next delivery. She quite liked him, on the whole.

The person waiting in the guild was *not* who Ryoka expected to see. She stared at Laken.

"I thought I was going to see you tomorrow! What gives?"

"Ah, Ryoka. I'm sorry about this, but it couldn't wait. Have you seen the weather?"

Ryoka grunted sourly. She had snow all over her shoes and Reynold, wheezing a bit as he came in behind her, was brushing snow out of his hair.

"It's coming down out there. Why?"

"Well, it's going to be far worse tomorrow, or so I'm told. The snow's going to cover the roads at least two feet deep—possibly as many as *four* on top of what's already fallen if what the [Weather Mages] are saying is true."

"Fuck. That's not good. Reynold, how does your carriage handle in deep snow?"

"Fairly well, Miss Ryoka. We should be able to return to Liscor—slowly, but even in deep snow."

"Well, that's a relief."

Laken shook his head.

"It may be to you, but Ryoka, the Merchant's Guild is saying they won't be able to deliver the food or have the adventurers escort us for at least a week until the roads clear!"

She stared at him.

“Can’t they melt the snow? Hire a mage who knows flame spells?”

“Too costly for me. If I had more money I could, but—no. And we can’t leave right now.”

“So you want to hire a Runner.”

Ryoka nodded. It was the best solution. She glanced at the Runners shivering as they came in from the cold.

“Hire someone good and give them a bag of holding. It’s pricy, but they might be able to beat the snows.”

“It’s a day’s run for the best of them. No City Runner will do it for fear of losing their way, and there’s no Courier I could hire—even if I could afford one.”

Ryoka stared at Laken’s grim face. She got what he was saying and raised her hands.

“Oh no.”

“Ryoka, please. The village will need food soon, and if I’m away for that long they’ll panic. If you can get to them and send a message—”

“No, I’m not—I’d get lost as well! Hold on, I might be able to if Reynold drives me.”

She looked hopefully at Reynold and Laken turned to the [Butler] as well. Reynold hunched his shoulders guiltily.

“I’m terribly sorry Miss Ryoka, but Lady Reinhart did not authorize me to drive you anywhere but Liscor. Under any circumstances. I believe her exact phrase was ‘if she needs to get anywhere, she can run there herself’.”

“Even to help a village?”

“Even then, Miss. You could try contacting her, but I’m afraid that until then, my orders stand.”

“How long would that take?”

As she asked, Ryoka knew that it wasn’t a good option. Lady Magnolia might say yes, but she’d want to know *why* Ryoka wanted to help Laken so badly. If there was any way to avoid that, Ryoka would.

“If it is not an urgent issue—and I am afraid that Ressa would not consider this such—Lady Reinhart may not receive your communications for a day or two.”

“And I need to be back in Liscor in two days for Christmas. Laken—”
He stood up.

“I know it’s a lot to ask, Ryoka, but you’re the only person who could do it. I can’t afford anyone else, and I don’t want to leave them alone

without word for so long. If you could take a bag of holding—the [Receptionists] assure me you could bring enough food for a week or two *and* some presents with their biggest bags.”

“Presents?”

“Yes. It’s going to be Christmas soon.”

“Yes, it is.”

Laken smiled a bit, but it twisted on his face with anxiety.

“You know, I don’t have a problem staying here. I can buy gifts for Durene and Gamel—after I explain the idea of Christmas to them, of course. But the people in my village need that food *now*, not after the roads clear. And I’d like to get them presents as well.”

“I know. I know, but—I can’t. I have to get back home and—I couldn’t find my way through a blizzard either.”

The excuses felt hollow in Ryoka’s mouth. She felt a twisting in her gut, but she didn’t see how she could do it. Running was one thing. She could probably run in deep snow—it would be hellish, but she could do it. But getting lost was another issue.

“If it’s just finding your way...”

Laken paused. He frowned, thinking hard.

“Is there a map you could take? Some sort of magical...GPS?”

It sounded ludicrous. Ryoka shook her head as she sat at one of the tables with him. Laken sighed and pushed the small bowl of cheese and crackers someone had given him away. Ryoka felt a rustling at her pouch.

“Is that food? I claim it!”

Ivolethe leapt onto the table and grabbed a slice of cheese and a cracker. She began munching it down. She was getting gluttonous, Ryoka reflected. She stared down at Ivolethe, annoyed the faerie wasn’t taking things seriously. Then Ryoka paused.

“Hey Laken. Ivolethe’s eating your cheese.”

“I don’t m—”

Laken went silent. He coughed and when he spoke again his voice had taken on a thoughtful tone.

“Christmas is coming up, Ryoka.”

“Yup. Santa Claus.”

“It’s a very famous tradition. I used to hear all the old tales every year. The German stories are different of course, but I’ve heard the American classics as well.”

“Oh yeah. All the good ones, I bet.”

“I especially liked Rudolph, although I can’t imagine what the color ‘red’ must look like.”

“It’s not bad.”

“I hate to ask you to run through a blizzard—”

“I’ve done worse. And I’d like to do it. It *is* the holidays.”

“But the issue is finding your way. Through a blizzard.”

“Yeah. I’d need a guide. Someone who can find their way. Light the way, rather.”

“I take it the color’s off? I’m told that uh, Winter Sprites are blue. Which is, apparently, not close to red.”

“It’s a bit different. But why don’t I think that will matter?”

Laken and Ryoka kept their voices low. They both felt it. A bit of holiday magic in the air, or perhaps just insanity masquerading as good sense. They turned their faces towards the small Frost Faerie gorging herself on the table.

Ivolethe happily swallowed a large bite of wrinkled prune and then realized she was the target of their scrutiny. Warily, she frowned up at the two Humans staring down at her.

“What? What are ye buggers staring at?”

3.41

Two days before Christmas, Ryoka stared up at a Frost Faerie and wondered how it had come to this.

“Come on, Ivolethe. Please?”

“Nae. I won’t do it!”

Ivolethe folded her arms and glared at Ryoka and Laken. The Frost Faerie hovered outside of the Runner’s Guild as Laken and Ryoka stood and argued with her. Durene and Gamel and Reynold were all standing a bit back, watching the young man and woman argue with what was, to them, a fuzzy patch of air.

“I’ll make you the Archduchess of Presents. How about that?”

“Not if ye made me a *Großfürstin*! I won’t act like an Ellylldan—like some common *pixie*! I refuse to guide Ryoka to your worthless little village!”

Ivolethe sneered at Laken and flicked snow at his face. He recoiled as Ryoka tried another tact. They’d been arguing with Ivolethe for fifteen minutes, but the Frost Faerie hadn’t budged.

“Come on, Ivolethe. We need your help. You’re the only one who could navigate through this snow.”

She gestured at the thick, falling snow around them. It was already piling up on the ground, and it made looking down the street a chore. Travelling outside would mean getting lost and freezing to death—for everyone but Ivolethe.

“Nae. Not even for friendship, Ryoka. My pride will not allow it.”

“Please, Ivolethe? Think of the children.”

The Frost Faerie paused. It was a low blow, but Ryoka saw it connect and pressed her advantage.

“They’re all by themselves in Laken’s village—probably hungry and cold. Think about that, Ivolethe. If I don’t bring food and supplies to them, they might freeze to death!”

“I’m thinking. So what?”

“You’d be doing a good thing. And you’d be a hero. I bet they’ll put up a statue to you, right, Laken?”

She nudged the blind man. He rubbed at his side and nodded.

“Oh, absolutely. I’ll put up a statue to you, Ivolethe. I swear it.”

The faerie wavered.

“Well...perhaps. But does it have to be *red*?”

Ryoka traded a glance with Laken. He didn’t trade one back.

“It would uh, be easier to see.”

He spread his hands and smiled up towards Ivolethe.

“Red is a very traditional color for Christmas, Ivolethe. And Rudolph’s nose was red. If you changed the color you...erm, you’d be doing the same thing as him. He was a hero, you know. Very famous.”

“Really?”

The Frost Faerie swooped down, intrigued. Laken nodded.

“Oh yes. Rudolph is...a, uh, legend where we come from. A folk hero, you could say. Beloved by all. Children everywhere in our world know his story.”

Ryoka held her breath. Ivolethe flew back upwards and muttered to herself. She looked down at Ryoka and sighed.

“A statue, ye say?”

Laken nodded.

“I swear it.”

Ivolethe sighed. She looked down at the two Humans and nodded slowly.

“Well then. What shade must I be? Red of blood? Red of desert sand? Red of setting suns?”

Ryoka could have cheered. She smiled at Ivolethe and held her hands up towards the faerie.

“Bright red. Crimson, in fact. Like a flare—like this. See?”

Ryoka held up her hands and concentrated. The [Flare] spell burst into life between her hands, a brilliant searing red light that made Gamel and Durene cover their faces. Laken didn’t flinch.

“I see. Let me try.”

Ivolethe frowned at the brilliant red light and closed her eyes. She gritted her tiny teeth and then the blue aura surrounding her began to shift. The color blue deepened, and then turned purple—then a deep red, and then the same shade of brilliant red as the light in Ryoka’s hand.

“Dead gods!”

“By the Five Families...”

Reynold, Durene, and Gamel reacted as the nimbus of light around Ivolethe changed. The faerie, her body of blue crystal ice now lit by a red glow which turned her entire form light pink, stared at Ryoka with a sour expression on her face.

“It is done. Let us be off, Ryoka Griffin. I dislike this immensely, but I will help.”

“Thank you, Ivolethe.”

The faerie stared at Laken, and then away. The [Emperor] turned to Ryoka as she bent to make sure the laces of her shoes were tied firmly.

“I can’t thank you enough for this.”

“Thank me after I’m done. It’s a long run, but I’ll try to be back tomorrow—or failing that, the day after that. I want to get back and then have Reynold bring me to Liscor. Hopefully I can make it in time for Christmas. If I can’t, well, this is more important.”

Laken reached out and Ryoka offered him a palm to grip.

“You’re a good person, Ryoka Griffin.”

“So you say. Myself, I’m not convinced.”

He grinned and stepped back. Ryoka was doing a second check.

“You have everything you need? Stamina potions?”

“At my belt, courtesy of the Runner’s Guild. Good thing these ones don’t freeze solid. Octavia’s are sort of crap.”

“And you have the second bag of holding?”

“Here as well.”

Ryoka patted the bag hanging at her side. It felt incongruous at her waist—far too light for what she knew it contained. Food for the village, extra blankets, tools they needed—and presents! And yet the bag felt like it only held five pounds of weight.

Magic.

She was ready to go. Ryoka stepped towards Ivolethe.

“Ready?”

The faerie didn’t answer her. Ryoka frowned.

“Ivolethe?”

The Frost Faerie was gazing towards the sky. She uttered an oath—it sounded like it was in Celtic—and sprang up into the air. Ryoka had no idea why—until she saw the other blue shapes flying down towards her. She groaned.

“Oh no.”

Laken turned.

“What is it?”

“Company. More Frost Faeries.”

“And that’s a bad thing?”

Ryoka didn’t answer. She heard the tiny, crystal voices ringing through the air as the faeries flew down, circling Ivolethe’s lone red glow and laughing.

“Sister, sister! What is this you do?”

“She’s changed her color! What rot! What foolishness!”

“Shut up! I do this for friendship and goodwill! Mock me not, fools!”

Ivolethe roared at her sisters, flying angrily at them as they laughed and flew about her. Ryoka saw the faeries hitting each other and felt a shock—the Frost Faeries played rough! They didn’t just pull at hair—Ivolethe bit one of her sisters in the arm and was mobbed by two of the others in return.

“Hey, stop, *stop!*”

Ryoka's voice stilled the fighting above her for a second. Frost Faeries abandoned their squabble for an easier target. They flew around Ryoka, pointing and jeering.

"Look, the boring one speaks!"

"So slow, so uninteresting! But she is with the ruler! Tell us, stupid one. Why is our sister red?"

"She's helping me deliver aid to a village. She's going to be...a hero."

The faeries scoffed and laughed, but Ryoka knew them. She raised her hands.

"You may not believe me, but Ivolethe is fulfilling a legend. She's going to make children happy. You see, there's a story about a reindeer called Rudolph—"

She got only halfway into her explanation before the faeries swirled around her, laughing with delight.

"A guide? What fun! We shall go too!"

"Yes, let us guide the silly Human!"

Laken blinked, and Ryoka hesitated. He sidled over to her and whispered as they laughed and flew up and around them.

"They're not like Ivolethe at all."

"Some of them aren't. I think these ones are...younger? Ivolethe's old, but some of the other faeries seem pretty gung-ho about anything that seems interesting."

"Is that a good thing or a bad thing?"

Ryoka scowled.

"I don't know. But it's better to have them on your side than against you."

"I agree with that."

A change in the light above caught Ryoka's attention. All of the faeries were copying Ivolethe, changing their colors. But they weren't all turning red. No, some of them were turning green, others blue or purple—in no time at all, a storm of colors flew about in the air.

"I can't believe it."

Reynold was gaping and Durene and Gamel were staring upwards like children seeing fireworks or stars for the first time. Ryoka stared too.

Faeries, dancing in the night sky in every color imaginable. She felt something stir in her heart, but quashed it. She had a job to do.

She cleared her throat, and the faeries stopped flying about. Ryoka felt some semblance of ceremony was needed here, so she stood straight and pointed west, towards where Riverfarm lay.

“Is everyone ready? We’re going to Riverfarm, Laken’s village. You know the way?”

Ivolethe flew down and the faeries lined up behind her. She scowled.

“Aye, these fools know. We go, then?”

Ryoka nodded. She took a breath, and felt just a hint of Christmas spirit in her. Maybe that was what prompted her to say what she did next.

“Alright then. On Ivolethe, on Blue Faerie, on Green Faerie, and Cinnabar Faerie! On Puce Faerie, on Indigo Faerie, on Yellow Faerie and—you know what? Let’s just go.”

The faeries laughed and flew ahead. Ryoka ran after them, cursing as her shoes slipped a bit on the snow.

“Good luck!”

Laken shouted after her. He couldn’t see Ryoka leave, but he heard her footfalls die away quickly in the snow.

“She’s gone, right, Durene?”

“Yes, Laken. Did you see—I mean, those Winter Sprites! I’ve never seen—uh—”

“You’ll have to tell me how amazing it was.”

Laken smiled as he held out a hand and Durene took it. He carefully felt around at the rucksack he was carrying.

“I hope Ryoka gets to Riverfarm all right. But I won’t worry about it. For now, let’s get inside, have something hot to drink, and rest. But before all that—Durene, this is for you.”

“For me?”

The half-Troll blinked as Laken pulled something out of the rucksack. He’d had to buy it when she wasn’t around with Gamel’s help, but the indrawn breath he heard from her was worth it.

“It’s a present. For you. Merry Christmas, Durene. I don’t know what I’d do or where I’d be without you.”

He held out the clumsily-wrapped box, and felt two large hands take it from him.

“I—I don’t know—this is for Christmas, right? But how did you—Laken.”

“It’s for you. Open it.”

“I’ve never gotten a present before. Ever.”

Something constricted in Laken’s chest. He reached out and touched Durene’s hand.

“Well, today you did.”

He smiled. Durene stared down at the small box. Her hands trembled. She began to cry.

In the city of Invril, a blind man reached out and hugged a half-Troll girl as the snow began to fall harder outside. At the same time, a young woman ran out of the gates, following a red light that flew ahead of her. A stream of bright lights of every color flew around her, the only clear light in the darkness.

“So, the presents will go here. If you’ve got them, put them here.”

Erin was busy in her inn the day before Christmas. She’d made a list, distributed it, and been happily surprised to find that most of her present-givers had already picked appropriate presents for the people she’d assigned them to.

Technically, they weren’t supposed to show her the presents, but Erin had forgotten to mention that presents were *wrapped*. A quick trip to Krshia solved that, and soon piles of bulky presents were occupying one corner of the inn.

It was a complex system Erin had devised, but in theory it meant that everyone who would be attending her party tomorrow would get two Christmas gifts. Assuming everyone bought presents, that was. Erin was worried she’d forgotten to include someone, but she *thought* she’d accounted for all who would be present.

And though they had only a day to get last-minute presents, Erin didn’t think that would be an issue. There was Christmas spirit in the air. Everyone

she knew, from both Celum and Liscor, had heard about the holiday tradition by now. And most were quite eager to try it.

There was just something about giving and receiving gifts that appealed to people. Of course, the receiving mattered to some more than others.

Twice, Erin had to pull Mrsha away from her gift. The Gnoll was sniffing it and wagging her tail, and Erin was sure Mrsha could tell what was inside. But Mrsha was a kid, so excitement was understandable.

On the other hand, when it came to people like Relc, it was a bit more objectionable. The Drake had come to the inn early to drink and eat, and he'd stared at the pile of presents avidly. Now he crept about the presents, turning them over and growing increasingly frustrated.

"Hey! Where's mine?"

Relc pawed through the presents, looking for ones with his name on it. He found none, to his increasing displeasure.

"Your Secret Santa might not have brought it yet. You'll get two, Relc, so don't worry."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah! Don't worry—Santa makes sure everyone gets a gift. Good kids, and bad ones. Although, the bad ones just get coal..."

"Right, I forgot. Santa, yeah. Where's that guy?"

Relc scratched his head. Erin hadn't talked to him as long as the others. She feared he might have gotten the wrong idea about Santa Claus—in that Relc hadn't figured out yet that Santa wasn't real. Still, she had more important things to do.

Some of the Gold-rank adventurers loitering about the inn watched as Erin climbed onto a chair and hung a large sprig in one corner of the room. They weren't inclined to risk their necks in the dungeon around Christmas, so they had plenty of time to spare.

"What's that?"

Revi wrinkled her nose as Erin nudged the collections of leaves and berries ever so slightly to the right. Erin turned and smiled wickedly.

"Mistletoe! Haven't you heard about that?"

Sensing something else interesting, more people drew over to look doubtfully up at the somewhat dead leaves and white berries. Erin had been surprised to see they were white. She'd always thought of them as red. But this was the mistletoe Krshia had given her.

“What’s that supposed to do? Are we supposed to jump up and eat those berries? They look poisonous to me.”

Ceria wrinkled her nose as she stared at the berries. Erin laughed and shook her head.

“No! You kiss if you’re under it! Any people who stand under mistletoe *have* to kiss. It’s a Christmas tradition!”

Not one she’d practiced at home or ever in her world, actually, but Erin thought it was a fun idea.

The change that came over the people standing before her was immediate, though. Ceria and Yvlon hurried out of the mistletoe’s radius as if they were on fire. The others stared at each other.

“Well, that sounds like fun! Hey Typhenous!”

The [Mage] was too slow. Jelaqua Ivirith caught him and kissed him on the lips. He shuddered.

“Agh!”

“Sorry. Dead skin and all that. But that’s the tradition. Hey, Seborn, Moore. Want to try?”

The other two Halfseekers shook their head. They’d stayed away from the mistletoe and weren’t approaching.

Halrac and Ulrien stared up at the mistletoe. They stared at each other. Ulrien coughed.

“Um, Miss Erin. Is there any hex or curse that activates if two people *don’t* kiss under the mistletoe?”

“No. It’s just fun.”

“Good.”

Halrac stomped quickly out of range. Ulrien followed suit.

“Well, I don’t see what the problem is. It’s just a kiss.”

Revi strolled over to the mistletoe, not standing quite beneath it as she looked around challengingly. She smiled mockingly at Typhenous who was taking a drink after being kissed by Jelaqua.

“A kissing game sounds fun. It reminds me of when I was younger. We’d swap mouths and kiss each other at parties.”

She tapped the stitch marks around her lips. Erin paused.

“Wow. Okay. Um, this is really just more of a tradition.”

“Why have a place to kiss if you won’t do it? Who’s good at kissing?”

“I’ll try.”

Pisces stepped forwards, to everyone's great surprise. Revi looked him up and down, but then she smirked.

"Why not?"

Erin opened her mouth, raised her hand, and then waved it about, but she couldn't stop what happened next. Pisces and Revi stepped beneath the mistletoe...and kissed.

It wasn't long. There weren't any sucking sounds or visibly tongue-in-cheek moments. But when it was done, Pisces stepped away looking slightly smug. And Revi—

Blushed.

Everyone in the room stared at her. Pisces sauntered back towards the other Horns of Hammerad and winked at Ksmvr. Erin heard the Antinium whispering to Pisces.

"I do not understand what happened. Comrade Pisces, please explain kissing—"

"Had your fun?"

Halrac asked Revi in an acidic tone as she stepped away from the mistletoe. Revi fanned at her face, glancing at Pisces.

"Well, that was surprising. He's...not bad."

"Not bad?"

Relc stared at Pisces. He laughed.

"You can't be good or bad at kissing!"

"That shows what you know."

Revi stared archly at him. Relc paused.

"Wait, you *can* be good at kissing?"

Revi, Typhenous, Ulrien, and Seborn nodded. Revi wandered back over to the mistletoe, and this time Jelaqua went with her. Other people from both genders drifted over.

Erin watched with part horror, part fascination. This wasn't how mistletoe was supposed to be used, surely! But it seemed like there was actual skill at kissing being measured. Some were better than others. And apparently...Pisces was one of the best.

"You know, back home I was told that anyone who could tie a cherry stem into a knot with their tongue was a really good kisser."

Erin mentioned that as she brought out some dried cherries she'd bought with that very fact in mind. Revi took a break from testing one of the [Actors] from Celum who'd come in for breakfast, and took a stem. She and

quite a few people popped the cherries into their mouths and chewed thoughtfully.

Erin glanced around the room as she circulated with ‘testing cherries’. Now that she looked...she had a good distribution of races and genders today. People had come from both Liscor and through the door in Celum. There were Drakes, Gnolls, and a lot of Humans, male and female. She glanced at the mistletoe, where a few red-faced people and more with smiles on their faces were grouped. She had a bad feeling she knew what was coming next.

“Peh!”

Ceria spat out a completely un-knotted cherry stem into the palm of her hand and scowled.

“Not for me.”

“Hrm.”

Revi had bent her stem, but not managed to tie it into a knot. Neither had most of the people in the room. Jelaqua had, but Seborn called foul because she’d done it with her Selphid parts, not her actual tongue. But then Pisces pulled out a cherry stem with a knot tied right in the center.

Everyone stared at him. Jasi came over and stood beneath the mistletoe. She waved a claw at Pisces. She shrugged at Erin as the [Innkeeper] gave her a betrayed look.

“This is so wrong.”

She muttered as she saw Pisces become a target for kisses from the opposite gender. Ceria, standing next to her, shook her head.

“You put the mistletoe up, Erin. What did you think was going to happen?”

“Not this! I mean, why’s Pisces getting all the kisses?”

The half-Elf shrugged, staring at Pisces and not looking at Erin.

“He’s...not bad at kissing. That’s why. It’s fun to kiss him. He certainly got enough practice back in Wistram.”

Erin stared at Ceria. She opened her mouth, and then turned away.

“I don’t want to know! Gah! Mistletoe failure!”

The entertainment for the day continued as Erin served food to her guests. Word spread fast, and within a few hours more people came from both Celum and Liscor—ostensibly to eat and get out of the cold, but mainly to try the kissing game, which was what the mistletoe had become.

Relc had lingered hopefully around the mistletoe for quite some time until he realized everyone was avoiding him. He stomped off, grumbling about stupid Humans, half-Elves, String People, and Drakes. He left some coins on his table and left the inn, feeling unhappy and out of sorts. No matter how long he'd waited, no one had brought a gift with his name on it. But Erin had said he'd get a gift! Two!

On the way back towards Liscor, Relc met Klbkch. The Antinium was hurrying up the hill and glancing over his shoulder. He seemed to be worried he'd be spotted.

"Yo, Klb. What's the hurry?"

"I am attempting to avoid meeting my fellow Antinium from the Hive. If you are asked, you did not see me."

Relc nodded in an understanding way. He didn't understand much about Klbkch's Hive or the relationship the Antinium had with the others—they all looked pretty much the same to Relc—but the Drake did understand not wanting to be spotted by angry people who had business with him.

"There's no point in going to the inn. Erin's hung a bunch of mistletoe up."

"Indeed?"

Klbkch stared at Relc. The Drake nodded grumpily.

"Yup. That means if you stand beneath it, you have to kiss. Only, no one wants to kiss *me*."

"Is Erin participating in this ritual?"

"Nope. But I've got bad news for you, Klb old buddy. Remember when Erin told us about the Secret Santa thing? With the presents?"

"Yes. I have obtained mine, although I have not placed them in her inn."

"Well, you might want to hold off for a second. I checked and I didn't find any presents for me. Not one. And I'm supposed to be getting two! And—get this—I didn't find any for *you*, either."

Klbkch paused.

"That is odd. Perhaps the gifts have not been placed yet."

"Maybe."

Relc shrugged moodily. He stared back at the inn, and lowered his voice as he confided in his partner.

“I’m worried we might not get any. Well, I know *I’ll* get some because everyone loves me. But you might not. Since you’re an Ant. Y’know?”

“This is a distinct possibility. The Secret Santas may object to my identity.”

“Yeah. So...I was thinking, why don’t we do a few good deeds today? I figure, if we show how Christmas-y we are, people will probably get us gifts anyways. Plus, don’t we get more presents if we’re good? That Santa guy brings them, right?”

Klbkch hesitated. He seemed to think as he crossed his arms.

“I did recall Bird mentioning something to that effect. But he was... vague. Is that what Erin said?”

“Yeah! Look, you weren’t here, but I heard her telling that thief-girl all about it. Good deeds means you get presents. So why don’t we do some?”

“I take it you have an idea in mind?”

“I might.”

Relc grinned as he rubbed at his chin. His dour mood had been replaced by a fun idea.

“Okay, here’s what I was thinking...I’ll run into the city and buy some stuff. You just need to find me a bag, a red suit, and uh, a beard. Make it white.”

“Very well. Let us proceed with your idea.”

The two [Guardsmen] headed back towards Liscor. That was fortunate for Klbkch, because an irate Antinium with blue shell missed him as she strode towards the inn.

Xrn opened the door and saw Revi step away as Typhenous hopefully tried for a kiss under the mistletoe. The Antinium watched with fascination, her ire with the elusive Klbkch forgotten as she witnessed several kisses... and those who didn’t get to kiss at all.

“Ew! Typhenous, *no!* Your breath smells horrible!”

The old [Mage] was crestfallen. He eyed Pisces as the younger man went back for round two with Revi. When Pisces was done, Typhenous caught the younger man.

“How is *your* breath not objectionable, young Pisces?”

Pisces paused. He took something out of a pocket and handed it to Typhenous. The mage stared down at the bit of green in his wrinkled palm. Pisces winked and whispered.

“Mint leaves.”

The old man stared at the leaves and then popped them into his mouth and chewed determinedly. The people who'd heard Pisces immediately left the inn to get some fresheners for their mouths.

Erin threw her hands up in the air.

"It's not supposed to be a *competition*!"

She stomped over to the door to Octavia's shop as Wesle hurried through it. Erin was going to close it, but Octavia called out.

"Erin! *Erin*! Get in here—I have something to show you!"

Erin paused at the doorway. She looked back at the kissing games, once again featuring Pisces as a main attraction and decided Octavia beat her inn. She walked through the door. What she and the occupied people of the inn didn't notice was Mrsha, bored with the proceedings, slipping into Octavia's shop as well.

"What have you got, Octavia?"

"Behold!"

The [Alchemist] was waving a bundle of what looked like twigs to Mrsha in front of Erin's face. The Gnoll squinted and sniffed quietly as she hid in Octavia's shop. She knew she wasn't supposed to be here, but there were so many fascinating smells here! And Octavia had something strange in her hands.

They looked like small sticks, but with a bulb of...well, something strange on the ends. Erin had recognized them, though.

"Matches! No way! That's it, exactly! Do they work?"

Octavia beamed, nodding and making her dreadlocks swing as she held one up to the light so Erin could see.

"It's my newest creation. It's not stable—I could do more with it, but you see, I've found a way to blend just a tiny bit of Corusdeer horn with sulfur and—look!"

She swiped the match down the side of the sandpaper box. Erin and Mrsha both gasped as the head of the match suddenly burst into flame. The Gnoll stared avidly at the flame on the end of the stick. How had Octavia *done* that? She'd simply moved the match...and there was fire! Was it magic? The Gnoll cub desperately wanted to try to do the same.

"You did it! That's incredible! How'd you do it in one day?"

"Well, when you're a talented [Alchemist]—I uh, might have made a few dozen prototypes. And stayed up all night. But once I realized how the general idea worked, it just came to me!"

Octavia's eyes were more than a bit red and she was swaying slightly on her feet. She put the box of matches on her counter as she explained more about how she'd made them to Erin.

Mrsha crept towards the counter. She hesitated—Erin and Octavia were right next to her. But Erin was pointing back towards the open door to her inn and loudly complaining about Pisces kissing all the girls—and them enjoying it!

Octavia looked over, and Mrsha stood up. She snatched the box of matches and scampered away, silent as a moth in the moonlight.

"I'll give you a box. I can make a lot more—and if I perfect the formula, I'll be selling them for silver coins!"

"Not bronze?"

"I'm not giving my product away for nothing, Erin! But...let's just say I'll be making a bundle if I get this business off the ground. And I have you to thank for it!"

"Cool! How much is my cut?"

The [Alchemist]'s eyes widened. She began to splutter, before she saw Erin's teasing grin. Still, that was an important point. Octavia took a breath and then she saw the door to her shop open, and a small bundle of white fur scamper out.

Mrsha held one of the new matchsticks up in the cold morning air as she proceeded down the streets of Celum. Quite a few people were staring at her—Gnolls weren't common at all in this city. Mrsha ignored them, and stopped by a street crossing.

How had Octavia done it? She'd just struck the match—pulled it fast against the side of the sandpaper. Like—

Mrsha slowly grated the matchstick against the sandpaper. It didn't work. But then she moved her paw faster and the head flared and burst into flame!

Mrsha instantly dropped the matchstick in alarm. It went out as it landed in some snow. She peered at the stick, heart beating fast.

Fire! She'd made fire!

It was an instinctual thing, for Gnolls to love fire. Like Humans and Drakes, it was that which had helped them separate themselves from the

part that was simply wild. It had brought order and light into the night, shown them that they didn't have to hide in the darkness.

And Mrsha had made it. Without a flint and rocks. Without the need for dry tinder and time. She'd made fire.

And it had gone out. Mrsha rooted around in the snow, and found the matchstick again. She tried to reignite the head, but it was burnt out.

So they only worked once. But that was okay—the box Mrsha had taken had plenty of matches. She drew another, and lit it.

The small flicker of light on the cold winter day was insignificant. Small. It was something that would have passed unnoticed in Erin and Ryoka's world—well, excluding the present. Any child doing that on a street now would probably cause a bomb scare. But in general, the match was an antiquated, ordinary thing. Who would pay attention to Mrsha and her box of matches in the cold?

Everyone, that's who. A woman passing on the street stared as Mrsha lit the second match and held it up in the wind. She blinked at the Gnoll. She suspected magic, but the way Mrsha blew out the flame and then lit another match informed her that it was not magic. She stopped and spoke to the Gnoll.

"How did you do that?"

Mrsha looked up in alarm. She understood the woman, but the first thing in her mind was guilt. Did she know Mrsha had taken the box without asking? Mrsha scampered away.

"Hey, wait!"

Mrsha ran back towards the shop. Then she saw who was striding down the street and ran back. Octavia caught sight of Mrsha and shouted.

"There you are! Wait you little minx!"

There was a certain tone adults could use that told children the consequences of not obeying would be far worse than if they did. Mrsha halted reluctantly. She hid the match box behind her as Octavia strode over.

"I saw that! You're...Mrsha, right? Well, that box belongs to me. You can't just go around taking things—even if Erin does take care of you! Give it back!"

She held her hand out. Mrsha eyed it and clutched the box tightly. She didn't want to give it back! The matches were magical in a way that magic wasn't!

“Come on. They’re mine—you can’t take them! If you want them, you can get them from Erin. Now give...them...here!”

Octavia was engaged in a tug-of-war with Mrsha when the woman who’d seen Mrsha light the match coughed politely.

“Excuse me, are you the creator of those things?”

Then Octavia let go and Mrsha tumbled backwards with the box of matches. She fled a few feet away and turned to watch as Octavia stood and smiled sheepishly at the woman.

“I am, Miss. I’m sorry you had to see that—a bit of reclamation of lost goods, I’m afraid. Don’t worry—they’re not dangerous.”

“Oh, I know. But I was wondering—do you have any more?”

“More?”

Octavia blinked.

“I’d love to buy some of these—flame strikers? I’m no [Mage] and these seem far quicker than flint and steel. What do you charge for a box?”

The woman was already pulling out a purse. Octavia gaped, but then she put her best smile on her face.

“I happen to have a few—they’re very experimental and new, of course. But I think I can quote you an affordable price...”

Mrsha watched, eyes narrowed, as coins changed hands. The woman went away with a box—half filled with matches—and Octavia pocketed a few silver and bronze coins. Mrsha backed away warily as Octavia turned towards her. Only this time Octavia didn’t try to take Mrsha’s matches.

“Well now, *that* was interesting.”

The [Alchemist] took a few steps towards Mrsha. The Gnoll tensed, ready to run rather than be scolded, but instead the [Alchemist] girl appeared thoughtful. She squatted down next to Mrsha.

“Advertising, hmm? I never wanted to pay for that, but if you consider that child labor is free—why not? It’s worth a shot! Little Miss, would you like a job selling those match sticks for me?”

Mrsha just stared blankly at her. She didn’t quite trust Octavia’s smile, for all the [Alchemist] did it often. She edged away from Octavia.

“Wait—okay, not a job!”

Octavia waved her hands frantically as Mrsha looked down the street. She sighed as the Gnoll stared at her. Then Octavia smiled again.

“I don’t mind you taking the box of matches, Mrsha. I really don’t. In fact, you can have them! Light up all of them if you want! What if I gave

you these matches as well—”

Mrsha found a second box of matches pressed into her paw.

“—And you go out there and, uh, show them off? Drum up a little business? I’ll let you sell a few, and you can keep a third—half—okay, fine, you can keep what you earn. But you have to show people where you got them, alright?”

The Gnoll child stared at the second box of matches, and then up at Octavia with narrowed eyes. This wasn’t how getting in trouble was supposed to go, she knew. But Octavia appeared jolly all of a sudden.

“Just bring back people to my shop, okay? Tell them—okay, I’ll tell them. You just come back when you need more matches! I have to make more! A *lot* more!”

She reached out and shook Mrsha’s paw energetically. Then Octavia went back towards her shop. She turned back and mimed striking another match.

When she was gone, Mrsha scratched her head. She’d understood only a bit of that, but somehow, she now had another box of matches! She thought a bit more, and decided that this was good.

The Gnoll padded back to the intersection and sat down on the paving stones. The men and women of Celum stared at the Gnoll, white and beautiful, sitting in the middle of their city. And they stared as she moved something in her hands and it burst into flame.

Fire. Mrsha struck a match and stared into the small burning torch’s heart. She remembered fire. Fire was important in her tribe’s camp. It was something that gave heat, food, life. It was the center of their existence, in a way. It kept the dark and monsters and fear of the night at bay.

For Mrsha, it was memory. She felt the heat on her claws and flicked the nearly spent match away. Then she lit another one.

People walking down the street stared and pointed at the little Gnoll lighting matches. But Mrsha was far away. She stared into the fire and remembered home. She’d dreamed of tending the fires, of being old enough to manage her own camp site. And now she had the ability to create fires at will.

Another spent match fell into the snow and smoked for a second before extinguishing itself completely. Mrsha sighed.

So brief. So short. But while it lasted...

She lit another one, and the flame burned away a falling snowflake. It lit up part of the world, and a man walking down the street stopped and stared at the match held in Mrsha's paw.

It was very pretty. And warm. Mrsha just had to be careful, or the stick would burn down and scorch her fur.

That was Celum, and the small miracle that stopped a street. In Liscor, a different sort of event was happening. It was localized, and went from house to house, usually terrorizing families. They would have called the Watch, but that was sort of the problem.

In the house of the Bitterscale family, the father, mother, and young boy and girl Drakes were sitting down to eat some lovely, fresh Fortress Beaver roast. It was a happy family, untroubled by thoughts of adventurers, Goblin Lords, or the new dungeon for the moment. They were about to eat when someone pounded on the door.

"Who's that?"

Frowning, Wress Bitterscale went to answer the door. He opened it and found a huge Drake, dressed in an ill-fitting red costume—that was to say, leather armor painted red, with a red hat on his head and a lumpy bag slung over one shoulder.

"Hey! Is everyone here? Good!"

Relc grinned down at Wress. He pulled the door open wider and strode into the house.

"Wress? Who's there?"

Vessra Bitterscale cried out in alarm as Relc strode into the room. The two children stared up at Relc as he grinned down at them, showing off all his teeth. He dropped the bag he was carrying onto the ground with a *thump* and waved at the kids.

"Hey there! Merry Christmas! I'm Santa. Santa Claus. Where's your chimney? Have you been bad or good? I've got coal!"

The children backed away from Relc. He frowned as he rummaged around in his sack.

"What? Hold on—some of these are broken. I've got to—hey, Klb! Get in here and help spread the cheer!"

He turned and roared towards the doorway. Wress stared in horror as someone else entered the home. The two Bitterscale children stared up with wide eyes as an Antinium, tall and lithe, walked into the room. He had two swords sheathed at his side, and he walked like a soldier. He also had a rough beard made of goat's hair glued to his face.

Klbgch clicked his mandibles as he stared down at the children. They appeared to be rooted to the spot with terror. As this was how most children acted around him, Klbgch thought he'd made a good impression. He slapped his belly with a *crack* of chitin on carapace, making all the Drakes flinch.

"Ho. Ho. Ho. Have you been good children this year? If not, you will get the coal."

The Bitterscale family stared at the two guardsmen. They stared towards the door. But there was nowhere to run. And then Relc pulled out a clumsily wrapped dagger and tried to give it to the daughter.

Point-first. In fairness though, that *was* an accident.

She was...eight hours into her run? Ryoka had no idea, but she was cold, wet...

And not feeling too bad. Ryoka had downed the second stamina potion thirty minutes ago, and that was keeping her going. As she ran through deep snow, following the shimmering lights overhead, she felt the burning energy inside her, giving her legs the strength to run.

The Runners of Invrisil knew how to prepare for long treks. The Guild had not only given Ryoka several stamina potions to allow her to run all night, but they'd given her a healing potion as well. It helped with the chafing, the sore feet, and the occasional falls onto the hard ground. It wasn't fun running in the middle of a blizzard towards a village, but, Ryoka had to admit, it wasn't bad.

The Frost Faeries made all the difference. They flew ahead of her, lighting the way. Without them, Ryoka wouldn't have known where to go. But they led her on, giving her the surety that she was going in the right direction.

The only problem was her speed. Despite her potions, Ryoka still wasn't moving that quickly in such horrible conditions. Of course, she wasn't

going that slow either.

The snow was ankle-deep in the best of places and getting deeper by the hour but Ryoka had gotten used to running in such conditions. She wouldn't have called her progress fast, but when she stuck to the relatively shallower roads she made good progress. She might have to run late into the night, but she'd probably get to the village on time, especially with the stamina potions.

Unfortunately, not everyone saw it that way. The trouble had started five hours into the run. Ryoka had heard grumbling from up ahead, but it had been silenced by Ivolethe. Three hours later, though, she could hear the complaints from the faeries flying around her.

“Hurry up, slow slug! We don't have all day!”

“Yes, run faster! Snail! Worm!”

They were getting bored. That was the problem. The other faeries that had joined Ivolethe had quickly lost the spirit of giving and regained the spirit of boredom.

And spitefulness.

Ryoka felt a snowball smack her on the back of the head. She gritted her teeth. She'd forgotten how objectionable most Frost Faeries were. Ivolethe was sweet as candy compared to her sisters.

“I'm moving as fast as I can.”

“Not fast enough!”

“Yes, we tire of this! Let's do something *interesting*!”

A chorus of voices agreed with the second speaker. Ryoka shook her head.

“If you're tired, you can leave. I'm going to keep running, though.”

The faeries grumbled, but made no reply. They flew away from Ryoka, letting their lights fade in the flurrying snow. Ryoka prayed they'd left as she continued onwards, following the edge of a pond of some kind. She stared at Ivolethe's red light ahead, using it as a compass.

It turned left. Ryoka followed it—

And found herself tumbling down a cliff. She shouted in confusion as the ground gave way beneath her and she slipped and fell downwards. She

hit the ground and lay there stunned for a second. Then she found her voice.

“*Ivolethe!* What the hell was *that!*?”

“It was not me!”

The faerie flew towards Ryoka as the girl got up. Ryoka took a step towards Ivolethe, but then she spotted another red light floating towards her. And another. And another—

“Hah! We got her, sisters!”

“She fell! Let us do it again!”

The other faeries, now all glowing the same color as Ivolethe, swooped around Ryoka, crowing with delight. Ryoka swore loudly.

“You have *got* to be kidding me! Stop that! I need to get to Riverfarm!”

“Hah! This is far more fun than bringing you!”

“Yes, yes! She wants to go to that stinking village? Let her find the way. Only, which way is the right way? Choose, mortal!”

Ivolethe, or a faerie that might have been her, swooped closer to Ryoka’s face.

“This way. Ignore those fools!”

Another faerie flew past her.

“No, you idiot! This way! I’m the real Ivolethe, not that faker!”

“No, it’s me!”

“Nae, I!”

“Ignore all these clods! Run, and do not look back!”

Suddenly, all the faeries were flying around Ryoka, in every direction. She swore as the red lights spread out around her, each one shouting her name. Ryoka cupped her hands to her mouth.

“Ivolethe! Tell me about my German!”

“‘Tis rot! A moose gargling a toad sounds far better!”

One of the faeries ahead of Ryoka shouted that. Ryoka grinned and ran towards it as the other faeries made annoyed noises. Ivolethe led Ryoka onwards, but now the other faeries were flying around Ryoka, getting in her way, spraying her with snow—

And trying to lead her astray. Like the will o’ wisps that Ivolethe had resented being compared to, the faeries tried to confuse themselves with Ivolethe, flying in her path and then breaking away. Ryoka attempted to keep her eyes on Ivolethe, but the faeries constantly mimicked her voice, claiming Ryoka had been led astray.

Soon, Ryoka had no idea if she was following the right Ivolethe again. She shouted, got a response, and set off once more. But again the faeries made her progress grind to a halt.

“Fuck you!”

She shouted up at the glowing red lights flying in every direction. The faeries laughed mockingly. Ryoka felt despair and fury building in her chest. She couldn’t get lost out here! But there was no way to get rid of the faeries! And she couldn’t tell them apart!

As Ryoka stumbled onwards through a forest with faeries shouting and flying in every direction, she heard and felt the earth *rumble*. The Runner turned and saw something huge moving to the left. The ground itself heaved upwards as faeries cried out in alarm and scattered.

“What in the name of crap is *that!*?”

Ryoka sprinted away as the snow erupted and something swiped at the faeries who had been shouting so loudly a second ago. They flew away as Ryoka saw the thing heave itself up even higher.

Higher. And higher. It rose, a colossus, out of the ground. No—it wasn’t *out* of the ground. Ryoka realized to her horror that it had been the ground itself! It had been slumbering, until her noisy passage had woken it. But now it rose, and turned towards her. She saw it.

A giant face. A wall of ice. Broken shards. Melted snow. Two massive eyes formed of rock. And then the mouth opened. The Frost Golem *roared*, its voice the sound of crashing snow and grinding stone.

The faeries screamed back. A flurry of red lights flew up and dove at the Frost Golem’s face, striking it with ice and wind, castigating the massive creature for interrupting their fun.

The ice was probably no harm at all to the Golem, but it disliked the attacks. It swiped at the faeries, and they flew away, jeering at it as they effortlessly dodged the large creature. But they had been distracted, and the Golem began to chase after them, roaring in a voice that shook the entire forest.

“Quickly, Ryoka! While they are distracted!”

A single red light flew down. Ryoka saw Ivolethe beckoning her onwards. Ryoka took one look at the Snow Golem and froze. It was chasing the Frost Faeries away, giving them a far larger target to harass. But that wasn’t what made her eyes go wide and her knees suddenly weak.

“No way.”

“What is it, Ryoka?”

Ivolethe stared at Ryoka’s pale face. The girl swallowed hard.

“I can’t believe it. I can’t. It’s not possible.”

“What, what?”

Ivolethe peered at the Snow Golem, but couldn’t see anything odd about it. She urged Ryoka onwards as the Golem thundered away from them, making the ground shake. Ryoka ran on, turning her head to watch the Snow Golem.

It was impossible. And yet—Ryoka saw it so clearly as she broke out of the forest, following Ivolethe. The Snow Golem was a distant shape in the distance, already nearly obscured by the blizzard.

It was just a Snow Golem, a natural phenomenon in this world. It didn’t look like a classic snowman at all; it was a mountain of ice rather than three spheres stuck together. And yet—

It had a hat.

The black mass on its head was too much like a top hat for Ryoka to call it anything else. Her brain knew it was probably some trees or boulders sticking out at odd angles. That, combined with the darkness made it *look* like a hat. That was all.

But still, she saw it. The Snow Golem wore a hat on its head as it roared and chased the other faeries away. Ryoka stared after it, and then began to hum under her breath. She turned and called out to the hovering faerie glowing crimson.

“Ivolethe? Let’s go.”

The faerie led her onwards. Ryoka pumped her legs, put her force into her stride. She ran onwards, bringing gifts and relief for a village that needed it. But her head turned one last time as she ran. She spoke under her breath.

“Thanks, Frosty.”

A distant roar was her only response. Ryoka smiled, and kept running.

A few hours after Mrsha had lit her first matchstick, she lit the one hundred and twenty third and watched the flame slowly eat away the stick. She held it close to her face and felt the heat warm her paw. Then she looked up and around Octavia’s shop. It was getting quite noisy.

“I’ll take five boxes!”

“Six, here! I’ll pay with silver!”

“A gold coin if you show me how to make them! Five!”

People were quite agitated about the matchsticks Mrsha was having so much fun lighting. Mrsha understood and didn’t understand at the same time. To her matches were fun, enjoyable, and magical. To the people who’d followed her off the streets and into Octavia’s shop, they were something more.

They were crowded around Octavia’s shop, Humans, Drakes, and Gnolls alike. Adults shouted for the [Alchemist]’s attention, demanded to know if this was her invention—if she would sell them the matches for the same price Mrsha had. Octavia was under siege at her counter. Mrsha saw her desperately waving one of her arms over her head with the other to get people’s attention, but it was no use.

There were so many bodies in the shop that the door was stuck open, letting the cold snow blow into the building. Snowflakes whirled around Mrsha. One struck her match and put it out.

Mrsha let the spent match drop to the ground and looked around. So many people. So many burnt matches. They were small things, but

important. New. Bright.

Then Mrsha sneezed. It was cold, even for her. She peered at the last burnt matchstick and decided she was going home.

The Gnoll padded between the legs of the adults and opened the door back to Erin's inn. She walked through, and carefully closed the door behind her.

"Mrsha! Where have you *been*?"

A voice made Mrsha spin guiltily. Lyonette strode over to her, all worry and loving concern.

"I've been looking for you all day! You're freezing! Did you go outside? I told you to tell me when you do that!"

She ushered Mrsha out of the way of a Gnoll and Drake couple who were kissing at each other.

"Into the kitchen. I have something to show you—oh, rats! Wait here. I've got to clean up a spill."

Mrsha obediently padded into the kitchen. There she relaxed as the snow on her fur began to melt. Something dug into her side as Mrsha stretched—she pulled out a small pouch, her pouch, filled to the brim.

Mrsha sat and emptied the bulging money pouch onto the ground. Coins *clinked* as they fell onto the ground. People had given Mrsha a lot of coins for her matches. And Octavia kept giving her more matches, so things had just sort of piled up.

A small mound of wet coins lay on the clean kitchen floor. Mrsha sniffed at the coins. They smelled like metal and sweat and dirt. She carefully picked them all up and stood up. Clumsily, she walked on two legs to the small pottery jar that Lyonette had put on the counter in the corner of the kitchen.

It took Mrsha two tries to jump and pull herself up onto the counter. But then she was right next to the jar. Mrsha opened the lid and carefully dropped the coins into the jar. They made a lovely *tinkling* sound as they fell. Then she put the lid back in place.

"Mrsha!"

The Gnoll child jumped. Before she could move, two hands lifted her away from the jar. Lyonette scolded her as she lifted Mrsha up.

"You know you can't take money from the jar! Do you want some coins? I can give you a few bronze ones—but no taking without asking, alright?"

Mrsha squirmed in Lyonette's arms. The girl sighed.

"Oh, you! Here. Sit there for one more second, and I'll give you a treat, alright?"

Lyonette went over to one of the ovens and pulled something out. Mrsha's nose made her sit up and her stomach rumbled as she saw a huge pan of golden bread appear from out of the oven.

"What do you think of this?"

Lyonette gleefully turned and showed it to Mrsha. She picked up a stick of butter that had been chilled next to the window and began to rub it over the top of the fresh bread as she explained.

"Erin has some—what did she call it? Baking powder, that's right! It makes the bread puff up like this! She made some and it smells delicious, don't you think?"

Mrsha did think. She licked her lips and stared avidly at the freshly baked bread. The stick of cold butter that Lyonette had rubbed all over the tops had made the bread glisten. Mrsha had never seen bread so *plump* and full.

She greedily reached for one roll, but Lyonette smacked Mrsha's paw. The Gnoll gave her an injured look, but Lyonette was unmoved.

"You can have some with everyone else. Come on, let's bring this out. You can carry a pitcher of m—actually, why don't you take the butter? Don't trip!"

Obediently, Mrsha took a saucer of warm, soft butter out into the kitchen. Her stomach was rumbling, and she could already almost taste the wonderful bread in her mouth. She smiled as she walked unsteadily out of the kitchen and put the butter on a table. She had already forgotten about Octavia and her latest invention.

Mrsha liked matches, but she liked being here a lot better.

"Bread's ready! Oh—for crying out loud!"

Erin turned from the freshly-cut pieces of steaming bread coated liberally with butter and nearly ran into a couple smooching hard under the mistletoe.

"Oops."

Selys and a Gnoll that Erin didn't know jumped apart from under the mistletoe. The Gnoll was blushing—he was a bit younger than Erin, and clearly embarrassed to have been caught out. Selys grinned and waved at the scowling innkeeper.

“Hi, Erin. I uh, heard about the mistletoe. I thought I'd give it a whirl.”

“You and everyone else! I'm sick of it!”

“Aw, come on. It's fun!”

So said Revi, although her lips were a bit puffy from repeated mouth-to-mouth contact. Erin sighed. She beckoned Selys over and whispered to her.

“Kissing is fine. Just don't kiss Pisces, no matter if he offers, alright? He's getting a fat head because he thinks he's such a good kisser!”

Selys' eyebrows rose as she glanced over. Pisces was looking more smug than ever as he sat at a table with Ksmvr. Ceria and Yvlon were sitting at another table, ignoring him.

“He's good?”

“So I'm told.”

Erin made a face as Selys eyed Pisces. She looked around and found a few cherries on a tray.

“It's become a huge thing. People come in, kiss each other, and try to tie knots with cherries. I'm making money, but I feel bad doing it!”

“What's so special about cherries?”

Erin explained about tying knots in the stems. Selys looked intrigued.

“That sounds like fun! Give me one.”

She chewed the cherry thoughtfully as Erin sighed and began to offer bread to her hungry hordes of customers.

“You look tired. Why haven't you gotten a few kisses? It's fun!”

“I don't want to. Especially not with Pisces.”

Erin frowned at Selys. The Drake shrugged. She took the cherry stem out of her mouth and handed it to Erin. The [Innkeeper] took it automatically.

“Suit yourself. But—and I'm sorry about this, Erin—I've got to see what the best kisser's like. Hey, Pisces! Come over here, you!”

The [Necromancer] looked up as Selys waved to him under the mistletoe. He smirked and came over. Erin shook her head.

She turned away, and then remembered Selys had given her the cherry stem. She glanced down at it. The girl blinked as she saw the cherry stem, tied into a double-knot.

She looked up as she heard the laughter and a cheer. Selys sauntered away from Pisces to a round of applause from the room. Erin had apparently missed the kiss of the day, and it must have been some kiss, because Pisces was bright red.

He turned away from Selys as she laughed and pulled at another Drake, giving him a quick kiss. Erin stared at Pisces, at Selys, and then laughed.

“Hah! Take that!”

Then someone kissed *her*. Erin felt the brush of whiskers and a wet smooch on her cheek. She yelped, and looked around. A white, furry face stared at her. Mrsha, perched on the table, held a bit of mistletoe with one claw. The girl stared at her. Mrsha licked her cheek. Erin laughed, and then reached out and kissed the Gnoll on her furry cheek.

“Oh, you.”

Five minutes later. Halrac was sitting by himself, sipping from his drink and not-quite-scowling around the room. For him, it was as good as a smile. He must have been drunk, or just off-guard, because he only reacted when he felt the wet kiss on his cheek. And then, simultaneously, another one on the other side.

“What the—”

Halrac turned, a hand on the dagger at his belt. He saw two large, brown eyes. Mrsha licked Halrac’s stubbly cheek. The [Scout] stared at her, and then turned his head towards the other mysterious kisser.

“Merry Christmas, you grumpy old man!”

Revi grinned at Halrac as she held a sprig of mistletoe over his head. Halrac stared at her, and then at Mrsha, who was sniffing at his drink. He rubbed his cheek and grunted. Revi laughed and spun away. Mrsha leapt from the table and went to get more bread.

Now that the kissing was mobile, everyone was fair game. The mistletoe changed hands quite a few times and left the inn in the pockets of some of the guests. Eventually Erin called for a ban on kissing—if only so that she could serve everyone hot bread.

Halrac sat at the table in the corner by himself, chewing the hot bread and remembering eating something similar back when he was young—although he’d had warm milk back then. He stared around the busy room, at friends and people he hardly knew, having fun and celebrating. The [Scout]’s face didn’t change as Ulrien called him to come over and throw a hand of dice. He waved in denial and sat by himself. Alone.

When he was quite sure no one was looking, the [Scout] smiled. Just for a moment.

Relc and Klbkch sat in an alleyway, staring blankly at the brick wall ahead of them. Neither Drake nor Antinium said much.

Relc was holding the bag of banged-up presents in his claws. It was still full. Klbkch's beard was slipping off his face again. The glue had ripped free from his chitin.

"What are we doing wrong here, Klb?"

"I do not know, Relc."

"We're trying to be like Santa, right? I mean, I'm dressing up like him and everything! Why are people kicking us out? They don't want our presents!"

"It is a quandary. I believe our efforts, while well-intentioned, have the opposite effect."

"Yeah. Wanna give up?"

"That may be best. Let us retire to Erin's inn."

Klbkch and Relc got up slowly and walked out of the alleyway. They walked down the street, ignoring the curious and horrified looks with their heads down. They only looked up when they heard the crying.

Someone was upset. Someone was weeping. And there was the sound of breaking pottery—from one of the houses ahead of them. Relc nudged Klbkch.

"They sound upset, don't they, Klb?"

The Antinium stared at the house's door. It seemed...unhinged, as if it had been knocked off its frame.

"Indeed they do. Should we investigate?"

Relc nodded.

"One last time. Then we're done."

The two [Guardsmen] approached the door cautiously. Relc nodded to Klbkch as the Antinium took a position on the other side of the door. The Drake counted to three, and then kicked the door in. The *crash* made everyone inside go silent for a moment.

"Does anyone want a pres—hey!"

Relc's eyes narrowed as he caught sight of the two Drakes wearing masks over their faces. One was standing guard over two frightened Gnoll children as the other ransacked the house.

The burglars froze at the sight of Relc and Klbkch. Oddly dressed though they might be, the Senior Guardsmen were a known duo in Liscor.

"Well, well, well. It looks like Santa's found someone who's been naughty."

Relc grinned and cracked his knuckles as the two thieves backed up. One whipped a knife from his belt out and stabbed at Relc. The Drake caught the blade barehanded and threw it away.

"Not sharp enough! Hi, nice to meet you! I'm Relc—I mean, Santa Claus! Here's my fist!"

He clocked the first thief in the face and then kicked him between the legs. The Drake folded up and Relc dodged back as the other one swung at him. He turned, twisted—his tail smacked the second thief in the face with a *crack*.

"You've been extra naughty! You're on my *list*! You got that, you punks?"

The fight carried out into the street as Relc *threw* one of the [Thieves] out of the window. The Drake landed with pieces of the broken shutters raining around him. He gasped for air and tried to get up—just in time to meet a black rock that smashed into the side of his face.

"Have some *coal*!"

Relc smacked the painted black rock into the offending [Thief]'s head. Klbkch tripped up the other as the Drake [Thief] tried to race out of the building. The Antinium calmly strode over to the fallen burglar and kicked him in the stomach.

"Ho. Ho. Ho. Merry Christmas."

The commotion attracted a crowd. Drakes, Gnolls, and some Humans watched as Relc and Klbkch beat the two burglars down, Klbkch with a brick, Relc with his sack of presents.

When they were done, the two [Guardsmen] straightened up, and heard the cheering. They saw the crowd applauding them, and realized everyone had a huge smile on their face. Relc turned to Klbkch. The Antinium was blinking down at one of the Gnoll children, who'd given him a hug.

"It's the holidays, Klbkch."

"Indeed it is."

“I think I feel the Christmas spirit! Look at all these smiling faces!”

Relc grinned as the father of the Gnolls came over to thank him personally. He reached into his sack and rummaged around. After a moment, Relc handed a battered present with a bit of blood splattered on the side to one of the Gnoll children. The young Gnoll sniffed curiously at the package, and then tore apart the wrapping. He stared at the wooden buckler and sword and grinned in delight.

Klbkch slapped Relc on the back. Relc staggered, and glared at him.

“Ow.”

“I am expressing my enthusiasm as you often do.”

“Don’t. That’s my thing.”

Relc sighed. He cracked his knuckles and stared around at the other children, who were already fighting over the presents Klbkch was handing out.

“That was fun. Alright. I’m done. Let’s get a drink, shall we?”

“Indeed.”

They left the bag of presents and fake beard and Santa costumes to be claimed by the excited children and pedestrians. Klbkch and Relc marched the battered [Thieves] to the city jail, talking along the way.

“Do you think that was enough good deeds?”

“I believe so. As we both regularly perform acts in service to the city, we should have accumulated an excess of good deeds this year.”

“Awesome. I wonder what I’ll get from the real Santa-guy. He’ll deliver the presents to Erin’s inn, right?”

“I would like a Dwarf-crafted sword.”

“Ooh, do you think I could get an enchanted spear? I left my old one back with the army.”

“We should ask Erin if Santa has any [Blacksmith] levels.”

“He’s gotta. I mean...presents, right? You can’t just make do with [Craftsman] levels.”

Klbkch was silent. He paused as he thought more concretely about Santa, and the odds of receiving a specialty-made item manufactured across the continent. For the first time, Klbkch questioned Bird’s scattered account of a Human man who rode a sleigh pulled by reindeer that flew.

“...It occurs to me Relc, that this Santa Claus that Erin has spoken of does not exist. The presents may in fact come from other people and are simply attributed to his presence.”

Relc paused. His tail drooped as he suddenly put some obvious pieces together.

“No. You think so?”

“If Santa existed, why has he not given us presents before?”

“Aw...no! I thought maybe it was a Human thing and we were included on his list since Erin knows us!”

Klbgch brightened up.

“That may be true. I did not consider that. Let us ask Erin whether that is the case.”

Unfortunately, both Drake and Antinium found to their disappointment that Santa was a myth. Erin laughed herself off of her chair when she heard what they’d done. But she gave them a hug and hot food, and so the [Guardsmen] felt a bit better by the time the inn closed.

“I guess we’ll get our presents tomorrow. I mean, if anyone’s left any. Doesn’t look like it.”

Relc sighed as he double-checked all of the presents. There were none for him. He sagged, and then turned, pulling something out of the rucksack on his back.

“Hey Klbg, I’m ready to go! Klbg?”

The Antinium turned. He had something in his hands. A carefully wrapped present, tied with a string of twine. Relc stared at it, and then remembered Klbgch hadn’t brought his presents yet. He stared at the nametag, and saw his name on the tag.

Klbgch looked at Relc. The Drake had a clumsily-wrapped present in his claws, the wrapping already torn a bit. But Klbgch’s name was clearly scrawled on the nametag.

“Oh.”

“Ah.”

The two [Guardsmen] stared at each other. Then Relc laughed, and Klbgch opened his mandibles in a smile. They put their gifts together and walked out the door, side by side.

“Merry Christmas, Relc.”

“Yeah, Merry Christmas, Klbg.”

The two sauntered down the hill towards Liscor, talking and chuckling over the events of the day. After a while, Relc frowned and stared back towards the inn.

“You didn’t get me anything creepy or wriggly, did you, Klbg?”

“No. Did you get me coal, Relc?”

“No! You’ll like it. I think. Yeah. Probably.”

Klbcch nodded.

“Well then. I shall see you tomorrow.”

“Yeah. I’ll open your crappy gift during the party. At least I know I’ll have one, even if it is icky.”

“Indeed. One is better than none. I shall contain my disappointment.”

“You do that. Later.”

The two parted ways without a second word. They didn’t look back, but both walked with heads held high.

They were smiling.

Late at night, the night before Christmas, hundreds of miles away, the villagers of Riverfarm were about to go to sleep on another miserable, ordinary day that was their life now. But the people who’d been posted sentry raised the alarm, shouting, as they saw something approaching their village in the dark flurrying snow.

“Who—who are you? I warn you, we’ve nothing to take! We’re under the protection of [Emperor] Laken! Begone if you mean trouble!”

Farmer Prost shouted as the dark shape ran towards him. He held a sword at the ready with two shaking hands. He’d never had to actually use it to fight; it was a memento from his father. He was about to swing when he saw the red light illuminating the distinct Runner’s Seal held in a gloved hand over Ryoka’s head.

She slowed as she approached the ruined village, taking in the destroyed buildings, the men and women holding weapons, and the frightened children. The villagers of Riverfarm stared as the strange figure pulled away a scarf and hood to reveal a young woman’s face. They hadn’t seen a Runner come all the way to their village in *years*. Most messages made the final journey via cart or wagon when they went to town.

“I’m a Runner. I’ve got a delivery from Laken.”

Ryoka had to speak several times to make her voice work. She had to say it again for Prost, who was staring at her uncomprehendingly.

“From—you mean from [Emperor] Laken?”

“That’s right.”

Ryoka groaned as she took the bag of holding from her belt. She felt like she was dead. Even with the stamina potions and healing potion, her feet ached, her body felt like it was falling apart, and she was numb. But she was here.

The villagers ushered her into their main living space, the renovated barn, and Ryoka sighed as she saw a fire had been carefully built in the center. She trudged over to it, and tried to set herself on fire to warm up.

“We haven’t had word since he left. We were sure he’d be kept by the storm—but he sent you to tell us he’s alright? Has he bought provisions?”

Prost hovered anxiously by Ryoka. She shook her head.

“No. He sent me to *bring* you them. Here.”

She handed the bag of holding to Prost. His face fell as he saw it, but then it changed the instant he reached inside. Ryoka, staring at the fire, heard the exclamations but didn’t bother to turn around. She wanted to eat the coals and let them warm her from the inside.

“Food! Dead Gods, there’s so *much* of it!”

“We’re saved! Praise [Emperor] Laken!”

Ryoka heard the commotion and the weeping. It was a while before she could tear herself away from the fire. But when she did, she saw...people. That was all.

She saw people. Just people, ragged, afraid. There was nothing special about them; they were just a frightened mass, suddenly relieved because good fortune had come their way. That was what Ryoka told herself.

They believed in an [Emperor], a false leader. Laken wasn’t—they’d put their faith in him blindly, and he’d delivered. But even so—

The man who’d talked to her, Prost, was in tears. He was hugging his wife and what looked like his daughter, tears streaming down his cheeks. Ryoka couldn’t face the raw emotion, the pure relief in his eyes. She looked away and clutched at her heart.

It wasn’t growing three sizes. It just hurt. She’d run hard, that was all. That was all.

They came to her after that, full of gratitude and heartfelt thanks. Ryoka backed away from it all. She didn’t want praise. She’d just—was just a Runner—

There was something in the air. That was it. Ryoka certainly wasn’t moved by a hug from a tearful mother, or a man taking her hand and bowing to her over and over, praising her for braving the storm. It was just a

temporary bit of insanity that made her take the bag of holding she owned, the one with the presents Laken had bought, and walk over to the children.

“Hello there. Have you all been good boys and girls?”

They stared up at her, wide-eyed. Ryoka crouched down as she tried to explain why she was here.

“I’ve got presents, you see. As well as food. Laken—your [Emperor] wanted to make sure you had something nice for the holidays.”

“What holidays, Miss?”

“Christmas. You see, it’s a special day where Laken comes from. On that day, everyone who’s been good gets presents. Who’s been good? I have a present for all of you! For you and you and you...they’re from Santa Claus!”

“Who’s that?”

One of the children asked the question, staring warily at the wrapped gift Ryoka handed him. She smiled.

“Haven’t you heard of the story of Saint Nicholas? Father Christmas? Kris Kringle? Really? Well, he has many names, but I always knew of him as Santa Claus. You see, where I come from, each year Santa Claus gets on his magical sled pulled by flying reindeer and flies around. He flies to every village, every home, every family in every city. And he gives presents to the good kids and coal to the bad ones. He hired me to deliver these presents this year.”

She winked at the adults. They caught on quickly, and smiled and shed some more tears. The children gathered around Ryoka, asking questions.

“Why didn’t he come last year?”

“How come he came this year?”

“Well...he normally doesn’t come out this far. But Laken knows him. He’s a friend of your [Emperor], so Laken got him to give him some presents for you all. Don’t ask more questions. Merry Christmas.”

She had a present for every child, but not all of them came forwards at once. One girl stood back. Ryoka turned to her, trying to give the girl her most sincere, not-scary smile.

“What about you, kid?”

The girl shook her head. She stared at the present in Ryoka’s hands, but then stepped back from it. She looked up at Ryoka with hollow eyes. And when she spoke, she broke Ryoka’s heart.

“I don’t think I’ve been good, Miss. My brother’s dead. He died in the snow and I couldn’t find him.”

“You—what?”

Ryoka paused. The smiles on the faces of the children around her died like dead lightbulbs. The adults fell still.

“It was the avalanche, Miss Runner. I woke up on top of the snow, but my brother—he was right with me when it hit. I dug down and around, but I couldn’t find him. He was right next to me. Right there. Just a few feet to the left. But I didn’t find him until the Emperor dug him up.”

The girl stared up at Ryoka, her eyes staring back through time. There were no tears in her eyes. They’d all fallen long ago.

Ryoka couldn’t get her throat to work at first. She hesitated, and then knelt next to the girl. When she spoke, it was very slowly, very carefully, looking the grief-stricken girl right in the eyes.

“I’m so sorry. It wasn’t your fault. I know you tried—you couldn’t have known. I’m so sorry. But you know what? I—don’t think that means you’re naughty.”

“You don’t?”

“I’m sure. Hey listen—what’s your name?”

“Anabelle, Miss.”

“Well, Anabelle, I think Laken agrees with me. You know why?”

“Why?”

“Because he told me to make sure Anabelle got a present. He told me to make sure you and every kid here got a present, understand? So he doesn’t think you’re naughty. In fact...he told me you might like this one especially.”

Ryoka pulled a present out of the bag and handed it to Anabelle. She took it, and stared down at the neat bow on it, looking lost.

“Why don’t you open it?”

“Are you sure? Did Emperor Laken really say that?”

Anabelle stared up at Ryoka, wanting to believe. And Ryoka lied. She lied straight to the girl’s face, and smiled because it was no lie but the truth.

“I’m sure. Here. Why don’t you open it? Just pull there.”

The girl pulled, and the wrapping fell away and she stared at the little doll, dressed up like an adventurer. Perhaps it was just coincidence that it was male, and it had blonde hair like hers. Or maybe it was magic. Faerie magic? Or just the magic of Christmas.

She began to cry. Ryoka reached out and gingerly hugged her. She whispered to the girl.

“You didn’t do anything wrong. That’s why Santa sent me. That’s why your [Emperor] brought all these presents. Now—why don’t we give you something good to eat?”

Anabelle sobbed into her coat and nodded. Ryoka looked back at the other children. They were teary-eyed as well, but that was fine. There was something important in those tears.

“Who wants to see what else I’ve brought with me?”

Hands rose hesitantly. Ryoka turned, and saw the adults standing, watching her. There was something in their eyes because they kept brushing at them. Hers too. Ryoka let Anabelle cling to her as she handed presents out. And then she had another thought.

“While we’re at it—why don’t I tell you a story? Would you like to hear a story? About Santa Claus?”

Ryoka sat on the straw floor of the barn and saw faeries land on the roof of the barn. She stared at them, but they made the interior of the building shimmer and glow. In every color. The villagers and children gasped, and Ryoka smiled.

“What are you staring at? Didn’t I say Santa was magic? Well, maybe he’s watching you. Now that I think of it...I’ll tell you stories about Santa, too! Did you know one of his reindeer has a red nose? Let me tell you about that. Once upon a time, on a night even snowier than this...”

Later then. So late that it was minutes away from becoming Christmas day, or the day Erin had decided was Christmas. She sat in her inn, her guests long gone, a pile of presents in one corner, and slowly cleared the last table.

“We’re done. Thank you so much for helping, Lyonette.”

“It was—nothing—Erin.”

Lyonette managed to get the words out between jaw-cracking yawns. She and Mrsha were dozing in a chair by the fire.

A single candle lit the room along with the fireplace. Mrsha stared at the flickering flame as it slowly wore down the wax candle. It was hypnotic, soothing. Before she knew it, Lyonette’s eyes were closing.

“You look tired. You should head upstairs.”

“I think Mrsha’s done. But she’s sort of restless. She had too much honey.”

Mrsha was indeed still awake, despite the late hour. She squirmed just a tiny bit, too hyped to sleep, but too tired to move. Erin smiled.

“Well, how shall we put her to bed? Hot milk? That always worked for me, or so my mom said.”

“I think she’s full to bursting. How about a song? I’d sing, but...I’m no [Singer]. Do you have the class?”

“I do, but you don’t have to have a class to sing, Lyonette. Why don’t I teach you some Christmas songs?”

“Oh. Can you? I’ve always liked music. They only sing the same songs in court back home...”

Lyonette sat up slightly, eyes shining. Mrsha perked her ears up too. Erin laughed and settled down in a chair across from them next to the fire.

“Why not. I’ll sing you...a classic song about Christmas. Okay?”

Silence was her only answer. Erin took a deep breath, and thought of the songs she’d heard growing up, when she had to go to the Christmas service at church, and sung by carolers and played on speakers and online as the world changed.

“Silent night, holy night. All is calm, all is bright...”

Her voice was the last thing anyone heard. The snow fell deeper, as across the world the night ended and a new day began. Nothing changed, but it was Christmas. And Erin sang.

“Sleep in heavenly peace. Sleep in heavenly peace...”

Her voice trailed off. Erin looked around and saw Lyonette and Mrsha had already fallen asleep. Erin sighed, glancing upstairs where their beds were waiting.

And she smiled. Just a bit. Erin stood up and found a blanket for the slumbering Mrsha and Lyonette. She took down the mistletoe and burned it in the fire. She took out the presents she’d wrapped for Klbkch and Relc and put them with the others. Then she stared out the window.

“Merry Christmas, everyone. To all good sleep. And too all...um. Wait. Oh well. Good night.”

Then she blew out the candle and went to sleep.

3.42

And then...it was Christmas.

Erin was up before dawn again, rubbing at her eyes. She hauled water, helped Lyonette finish cleaning the room—and got food ready.

That was what it was. Food. Erin mechanically created and seasoned a fatty soup with sausage, mushroom, vegetable extract, flour, garlic, a hard-boiled egg...all added to a rye flour and water base that had been mixed several days ago.

Sour soup. It tasted better than described. That was course one. But Erin had far more to do. She fried little dumplings with meat in the center – a Drake favorite food – toasted kebabs in the Gnollish fashion, and finished with some good old Human decadency.

Hamburgers, pizza, popcorn...anything Erin could think of she made. Because she knew she was going to need it all.

Her adventurer guests came and went, eating breakfast, and then lunch. Erin kept cooking, getting ready for the real meal. From time to time she pulled a piece of paper out of her pocket and stared at it.

On a delivery. Emergency—a village needs supplies and food. Will try to be back in time for Christmas. Ryoka.

She'd received it from the Mage's Guild. Erin stared at the paper each time, and then carefully folded it away. Each time the door opened she looked up hopefully. But it was never Ryoka. And eventually, Erin stopped looking for her. She had a job to do.

They began coming in at noon. First Relc, rubbing his hands and exclaiming with delight as he saw two presents with his name on it. Then Selys and Krshia and to Erin's delight, a tired Brunkr. His arm was bandaged and cleaned and he managed to smile at her.

At some point, the door to Celum opened and Octavia fell through. She slept on the floor. After a while Jasi, Wesle, and the [Actors] came through, along with Maran and Safry. Miss Agnes was not there, but Grev darted in as well and stepped on Octavia's head, waking her up.

After that, Pawn, Bird, Belgrade, and even Garry appeared. Erin had to come out of the kitchen to meet Garry and hug him. Anand was still in Esthelm, but the Antinium Workers had brought some more Workers and Soldiers with them. They sat in a corner while Garry offered his services to Erin. She accepted with relief and they went back into the kitchen.

The Horns of Hammerad hadn't ever really left, but Pisces came in with Ksmvr with last-minute gifts. They joined Ceria and Yvlon, who were sitting and drinking with the Halfseekers.

Griffon Hunt came to the inn around the same time as Klbkch did. The Antinium was not with the adventurers; he snuck in, looking guiltier than Erin had ever seen him. The reason for that was obvious; an irate Xrn followed him into the inn later. She would have dragged Klbkch away, but Erin presented her with a deep-fried bee and she stayed.

Who else? Erin was beginning to lose track. She was surprised when Hawk appeared, looking wide-eyed at her multitude of guests, but she had sent him an invitation too, hadn't she? And then came other people, Selys' Drake friends, some Gnolls that Krshia knew, more people from Celum...

One person came last, as the party was underway. Zel Shivertail stood at Liscor's gates, shivering a bit as the wind froze his scales. It was *cold*, far colder than yesterday. He would love to be inside and drinking some of the 'eggnog' that Erin had made. But he was outside, listening to someone he really didn't care for.

"If you're so worried, come and join the party yourself."

He snapped at Ilvriss as the Lord of the Wall stood, warm and comfortable in his heavy fur coat and enchanted clothing. The other Drake stared at Zel Shivertail with a look of incredulity.

"I would rather *eat* my tail than sit in the same room with one of the Ants. You seem to be able to tolerate them—and all those Humans. I am simply telling you what to look out for."

"I know what to look for. Anything. We don't know why Xrn and the other Antinium are here. Your precious city leaders and councils have oh so many suspicions and fears, but you know nothing."

Zel growled at Ilvriss. The Lord of the Wall was unmoved. He glanced towards the inn with a sour expression.

"Just listen and don't drink yourself under the table, Shivertail. We have a duty. You and I might have come north looking for that Human Runner, but this is far bigger than either of us."

“Don’t I know it. I’ll keep an earhole open, don’t you worry.”

The [General] turned away from Ilvriss. He began stomping towards the inn, moving quickly to keep out of the cold.

Quickly for Zel meant that he reached the inn in three minutes. He was still half-frozen by the time he did, but opening the door and feeling the warm rush of air on his scales and smelling all the delicious scents in the air made everything worth it.

“Uncle!”

Someone called his name. Zel looked around and smiled as he saw his favorite niece. The one who didn’t treat him like a living legend. Selys was sitting at a table with Mrsha, the Gnoll named Krshia, Olesm, and—Zel’s smile faltered a bit—Pawn.

The Drake only hesitated for a second. He came over and smiled as everyone welcomed him. He didn’t sit next to Pawn, but he didn’t sit far away from the Antinium either. Pawn he could tolerate.

“Uncle, I think that blue Antinium’s here. So is Klbkch. Don’t make a scene.”

Selys warned Zel, which was probably wise. The [General] stiffened, but Selys deposited Mrsha in his lap. The Gnoll stared soulfully up into Zel’s eyes and a crisis was averted.

Running about the inn, Erin felt like all was crisis. She lifted a pan up and yelped as the hot handle scorched her hands. She would have dropped the pan filled with fried ground beef and onions, but someone caught it by the base.

“Are you alright, Miss Erin?”

Garry held the hot pan without a care in the world. Erin blew on her hands as he put the meat back on the stove.

“Great, Garry! Your carapace is awesome, you know that?”

“It is a very helpful aid when I handle hot or cold objects. Or cut myself.”

Garry nodded. He lifted a basket of Erin’s new, ultra-fluffy bread up and carried it out into the common room. Erin followed him with a pot of butter and another one of honey.

Noise. And people calling her name. Erin smiled as people eating and laughing and playing games turned and waved at her. She put the food down in the center of the room and saw Mrsha leap off of Zel’s lap and make a beeline towards the food.

Someone who made a beeline towards Erin was Revi. The Stitch-girl [Mage] put her hands on her hips.

“Erin, please tell Octavia to *stop* trying to sell me things! Just because we’re both the same species doesn’t mean I’ll buy her insane potions.”

“I’ll have a word with her. Would you like some bread?”

Erin dealt with Revi as someone else came up to take a few warm buns and slather them with honey and butter.

“Miss Solstice, are you sure you have enough food for me? I am quite fine eating whatever—”

“I’m fine! Eat! Eat!”

The girl turned and smiled up at Moore. He smiled back and ducked his head. As the half-Giant walked back to his table where a bunch of the adventurers had gathered, he passed by two arguing Antinium. One, a slim Antinium with blue carapace, unique among her kind, was not happy with the other.

“You have run off to this inn and avoided speaking with me for the *fifth* time, Klbkch. What attracts you so?”

Klbkch the Slayer, one of the legendary Centenium, Revelantor of the Free Antinium of Liscor and acting Prognugator, hunched his shoulders as Xrn glared at him.

“It is Christmas. This is an important tradition that I must undertake to spread goodwill—”

“You spend all your time *eating* and talking with that Human. Does your Queen know you’re doing this?”

He did not reply. Xrn made an exasperated hissing-click that needed no translation.

“Once I am done eating this bee, you and I are going back to the Hive. We must talk, Klbkch.”

“But I have to obtain my presents.”

“That is no—what kind of presents? And is that honey I see over there?”

Xrn grew distracted as she saw the fluffy bread, sitting appetizingly on one table. She knew the Antinium could not process gluten well, even if her biology was superior to regular Antinium. It was inefficient, even so. But she still desired to taste the food.

“Honored Prognugator Xrn.”

A voice interrupted Xrn as Klbkch was sinking down in his seat. Both Antinium looked up. Ksmvr cringed as he bowed, but he still offered her the small trinket in his third hand.

“What is this? And who are you?”

“I was the Prognugator for the Hive until my...failures. However, I see your gaze upon the bread. I would like to give you this small token, that you might eat it.”

He offered Xrn the trinket he’d taken from the dead Goblin that resisted food poisoning. Xrn stared at the amulet, and then at Ksmvr. She closed his hand over the trinket.

“Fascinating. Thank you, Ksmvr. I have seen the spell and will copy it. Your help is appreciated.”

Ksmvr was stunned. He bowed and retreated, staring once at Klbkch. Xrn muttered to herself and tapped her chest, replicating the spell she had just seen.

“I had no idea such a spell existed. I did not look or think of it until now, but this is extraordinary. I should like to taste that bread.”

Beside her, Klbkch sat up.

“Will you cast that spell on me?”

“No. You do not deserve it. Why did you exile that poor Antinium, Klbkch? And why does he look like a copy of your former self? He walks like you. What has your Queen been up to?”

“It is a long story. If I tell you, will you cast the spell on me as well?”

As the two Antinium sat together, Ksmvr passed by Erin on his way back to the Horns of Hammerad. He saw her desperately calling for Lyonette to help her; she was balancing at least eleven dishes together on her way back to the kitchen.

“Let me.”

Ksmvr was preempted from helping by Typhenous. The mage lifted the mess of plates up and walked into the kitchen. Erin sighed with relief.

“Thank you so much!”

“Sorry, Erin! I was running to get more water!”

Lyonette came over, puffing from her run outside with the buckets. Erin saw several basins full of snow lined up by the fire, melting into water.

“It’s fine, Lyonette. Go back to serving if you’ve got time—I think Garry’s got the pizzas all ready. Now—who was calling my name?”

She went over and found Jasi wringing her hands. Grev was sitting at the table, glaring at Wesle as the former [Guardsmen] hunched over in his seat. Erin didn't see Relc at first; he was trying to hide under the table.

"What's wr—"

She felt the cold air and saw a hole and the broken glass. Jasi explained.

"They were playing a knife flipping game, but Wesle lost his grip and—I'm so sorry, Erin!"

"No problem. It's no problem—I'll just uh, board that up—"

Erin ran off. Relc came out under the table.

"Oops. How mad was she?"

It was Krshia who saw Erin run back with a hammer and nails and a piece of wood. The Gnoll stood up to offer Erin a paw, but Brunkr, sitting beside her, suddenly hissed and grabbed his Aunt with his good hand.

"*Aunt!* That's Zel Shivertail sitting there! I knew I'd seen his face before! That's him! The *Tidebreaker!*"

"Of course he is. He stays at Erin's inn, yes?"

Krshia shook her head as Brunkr goggled at her.

"If you'd been out at any time, you would have learned this. Go talk to him if you are so desperate."

"Talk? Me?"

Across the room, Halrac's keen ears heard Erin yelp. He saw her blowing on a finger she'd accidentally hammered and lowered his mug.

"Why's she got a hammer?"

Ulrien, sitting next to him followed Halrac's gaze. The [Scout] grunted irritably.

"Someone broke a window."

"That's why glass is risky."

Halrac's longtime comrade shook his head. Ulrien gazed at Erin as she took her tools away and stared at the rough patch on the window. The big man nodded to the [Innkeeper].

"Your friend seems tired."

"She's not my friend. And she's fine. She's smiling."

Halrac glared at Ulrien, but the leader of Griffon Hunt pushed his mug back and shook his head.

"How can you be a [Veteran Scout] with over 30 levels in your class and still not see the obvious, Halrac? Look at her. She's smiling, but she's exhausted."

The [Scout] looked, and this time he saw Ulrien was right. Erin was smiling, but she nearly tripped over her own bucket bringing it back into the kitchen. She had rings around her eyes.

“She needs to hire someone else. Running an inn’s no job for just her and a [Barmaid].”

That came from Hawk. He was sitting with Halrac and Ulrien, having made their acquaintance earlier today. He’d actually met them a few times while running deliveries, hence their easy camaraderie.

All three males watched as Erin ran over to help Garry and Lyonette put a positively gargantuan platter of barbequed ribs on the table. Erin rushed into the kitchen and came out with the fried potato strips she called ‘fries’.

“A hard worker. You were right when you said we should stay here, Halrac.”

Ulrien raised his mug and took a drink. He tilted it up for the dregs. Hawk nodded, looking hungrily at the fries. Some were made of sweet potatoes, and reminded him of carrots.

“This inn is hopping. And the food is excellent! I’d heard that Erin came up with new food every other day, but this is just impressive. You wouldn’t happen to know if anyone’s planning on moving out, would you? I’d love to rent a room...”

“Oh Erin! Erin!”

Halrac gritted his teeth as a familiar voice called out Erin’s name for the seventh time that night. Erin came over a bit slower than usual, because Revi was the one waving her hand.

“We need a refill! We’ve been waiting for five minutes already!”

“Coming up!”

Erin ran off. Halrac glared at Revi, sitting at the table behind him.

“Stop pestering her. Can’t you see she’s busy?”

Revi gave Halrac the condescending look he hated so much.

“She’s an *innkeeper*, Halrac. This is her job. If she’s too busy to serve drinks, she should hire someone else to help!”

“That’s what I said!”

Hawk leaned around Halrac to speak to Revi.

“Did you know there used to be a skeleton that helped around the inn? It was the talk of the city! I wonder what happened to it...”

Pisces could have told Hawk, or any of the Horns of Hammerad. But they were all busy watching Belgrade and Pawn take on the entire room at

the tables where the game of Go was being played.

The two Antinium played anyone and everyone who sat at their tables. They moved their hands quickly, placing white and black stones, easily defeating most players. Pisces and Pawn were engaged in a heated speed-battle where each player had only a second to place a stone, while Belgrade dueled Olesm in a slower, more thoughtful match.

“Erin! Hey, Erin!”

Ceria waved at Erin and the girl skidded to a halt as she carried drinks over to Griffon Hunt. In the background Revi groaned loudly.

“What is it, Ceria? Emergency? Need something?”

Erin tried to wipe sweat off of her forehead as she turned towards Ceria. The half-Elf shook her head. She raised a half-devoured rib and pointed to it.

“Good meat! I love the sauce!”

Erin stared at Ceria for a second. She opened her mouth, and then turned and hurried off.

“Erin! *Erin!* Hey, Erin! I dropped my fork and can’t find it! I need another!”

“When are we opening presents?”

“Do you have more vegetables? Too much meat gives me gas.”

“I’m sorry, but I need another bucket of water. Too much heat. Do you have any on hand?”

Erin measured the minutes by the requests she got. She ran back and forth, smiling trying to avoid adding to the mess on the floors, and serving drinks and food in between. She wasn’t aware of the time until Revi spoke up as Erin was serving her another drink.

“Is there any entertainment for the night? Or are we supposed to watch the Ants play that board game and chat and eat?”

The [Innkeeper] paused as Halrac and Ulrien both glared at Revi and she steadfastly ignored them.

“Entertainment? Um, like what? More alcohol?”

“No! Don’t you have someone who plays the lute, or tells stories?”

Revi stared around the room, eying the group of [Actors] hopefully. Erin wondered if they’d be able to perform, but her heart sank as she realized half of them were so drunk they could barely sit straight.

“I’ll see what I can do.”

“Why not sing?”

A laughing Drake who'd heard their conversation called that out. Erin turned towards him—he was one of Selys' friends and had scales which were pink. He might have claimed they were red, but they were more pink than red in Erin's eyes.

“What? Sing?”

“Aren't you the Human who sang that one time? I heard the music on Hessel Street, halfway across the city!”

“That's right! You could sing, Erin!”

Selys stood up and called it out. Heads turned, and after the guests at the inn pieced together what was going on, more raised their voices in approval.

“Sing!”

“I loved that song about defeating the Huns! Nice war song! Who are they?”

Ceria, sitting at a table and trying to talk herself out of eating another rib, sat up and nudged Yvlon. The woman stared as Erin was bombarded by calls to sing.

“Songs, huh? I remember Erin singing.”

Yvlon stared at Ceria. Their eyes found a table in the center of the room. Both remembered Erin singing. In a room full of adventurers, as she held an injured Pawn, singing into the night.

The half-Elf held her breath as Erin made her way into the center of the room. Erin was blushing, looking harried by all the pressure on her. But she obligingly grabbed a wooden spoon and used it as a fake microphone.

“Attention! Attention, everyone! I guess it's song time! I'm going to sing you a few Christmas songs from home—I hope you like them!”

“Finally.”

Revi muttered and got a jab from Belgrade in the side as the Antinium went back to sit at their table.

Standing in the center of the room, Erin wiped sweat off of her face and tried to think of a good song to sing. She felt so tired. But this was Christmas, and she had guests to entertain!

“This one's a song I hear—heard all the time back at home. Jingle bells!”

She took a breath, and people cheered. Erin closed her eyes—
And remembered.

The sounds around her faded. Part of it was people growing quiet, listening to her sing. But another part was different. It might have been magic, it might have been her Skill. But the guests in her inn suddenly heard a ringing bell, a beating drum, and then Erin's voice, singing a song from childhood. From home.

"Dashing through the snow on a one-horse open sleigh, o'er the fields we go, laughing all the way..."

Home. It was something she'd avoided thinking of. But here, in this moment, in this place, Erin couldn't escape. So she gave voice to that feeling in her chest, the memories.

Home.

Maybe that was why the next song she sung wasn't a Christmas carol. Erin sang a song from the band Journey. The classic. The story in the song that she'd danced to so many times as a kid. The song played in the 3rd Season of Scrubs.

Don't Stop Believing. The crowd in her inn cheered wildly when Erin was done. Some of them were rubbing their ears and staring around the inn for the drums and electric guitars that had been playing—others just sat, listening with mouths open to a type of music that had not existed in their world until now.

Erin smiled as people cheered her on, demanding another song. She immediately launched into the classic she'd sung for Lyonette and Mrsha, *Silent Night*. She sang with her eyelids shut. She wasn't standing in her inn anymore. She was somewhere else.

Where would she be if she were at home? She'd be...she'd be in her living room, eating with her mom and dad. She'd probably be laughing and eying the presents under the tree. Knowing her father, he'd have bought her some chess guide or a new board—her mom would get Erin some tasteful clothing that Erin had hinted she wanted. And Erin would be looking forwards to seeing her parent's reactions for the presents she'd bought.

Or—Erin's voice faltered. Would she be in college? She would have been in college after her one year break. Erin would probably have come home for the holidays, but—

"Erin?"

She looked around, and realized the song had ended. People were waiting for the next song. Erin smiled. She felt something building in her

heart. She searched for a song, and couldn't think of anything off the top of her head.

"Um—what should I sing next? Another Christmas song? Okay. Then I'll sing..."

It came to her without thinking.

"How about *Home For the Holidays*? Anyone heard that song? Well—"

Erin smiled faintly as people cheered and clapped. She took a deep breath and began. There was no accompaniment for this song. It wasn't an immortal moment. Erin felt her heart beating slowly as she began to sing, mechanically reciting the song she'd heard so many times.

"*Oh there's no place like home for the holidays—*"

Only when she was halfway through did Erin's mind catch up with what she was singing. She paused, and people looked up. She coughed, and felt something in her *stop*. The people who'd been swaying to the music paused and looked at her. She tapped her throat, cleared it.

"Sorry. Something was in my throat. Let me try again."

She opened her mouth, and tried again.

"Oh there's no place like *home* for the—"

Again she broke off. This time, the noise in the inn died. Erin lowered the wooden spoon in her hands.

Something was wrong. Her eyes were stinging, and the world was getting fuzzy. Erin tried again. She took a deep breath.

"There's no place like..."

Silence. Every eye was on Erin. The people in her inn had stopped. They stared at the girl standing in the center of the room. Erin's cheeks were flushed, her eyes bright. The last word she'd meant to sing died unspoken.

She dropped the spoon. It landed on the floor with a clatter. Erin looked around. Her eyes were bright and overfull. The word echoed in her mind, in her heart.

Home.

She wasn't home. She was far from home. And though she'd tried to forget, Erin couldn't. She remembered her parents, her home. Her friends. They weren't here. This wasn't her world.

Standing in the center of the room, Erin blinked and then lost the smile that she'd kept on her face for so long. Her mouth turned down.

She couldn't stop it, no matter how hard she tried. The world blurred. Erin's shoulders shook. Slowly tears rolled down her cheeks and fell onto the floor of the inn.

Drip. Drip.

Erin covered her mouth with her hands. She pressed the heels of her hands against her eyes, but the tears wouldn't stop.

Home. She missed *home!* She wanted to see her mom and dad again. She wanted to go to her room. She wanted it so badly that Erin couldn't do anything but cry.

No one could speak. Erin looked around, tears falling, unable to speak. Wide-eyed faces stared up at her, people soundlessly gazing at her.

She made the smallest noise, and then turned. Erin ran for the door to her inn and flung it open. She disappeared into the snowy night. The inn's door slammed shut behind her.

For a second no one spoke. All of Erin's guests stared at the closed door. Then Mrsha began to howl, and everyone began shouting at once.

The first few minutes were all chaos. Mrsha ran for the door, only to be caught by Lyonette. Ceria stood up and wanted to go after Erin, but Yvlon pulled her back. The Human woman tried to tell Ceria to let Erin grieve by herself at the same time Grev burst into tears and Klbkch flipped his table and stood up.

Some people went for the doors, but others got in the way or had other opinions. The noise was so intense that it became impossible to think or make sense of any individual voice.

In the end, Relc leapt onto a table and bellowed at the top of his lungs.

"Alright. Everyone *shut up!*"

He had a voice used to shouting in the middle of battles and over noisy crowds. Everyone grew quieter as they stared at Relc. The Drake looked around the room, and then hopped off the table.

"Damn it."

He kicked at a fallen cup. Relc stared at the door and sighed heavily.

"Someone should go after her. It's cold out there. And there's Rock Crabs and Shield Spiders hiding in the snow."

"I'll go."

Klbbkch, Halrac, Pawn, Olesm, Krshia, Selys, Ceria—there were fewer people who remained sitting. But it was Pisces who appeared at the door in an instant with his [Flash Step] spell. The mage looked around the room.

“I shall go. Discreetly. I know [Invisibility]—I shall make sure she doesn’t freeze and keep any monsters away until she returns.”

No one had anything to say, so Pisces opened the door and disappeared into the night. The others sat down and began talking amongst themselves anxiously in low voices.

“Happy?”

Halrac snarled at Revi. The Stitch-girl raised her hands, looking upset.

“Don’t glare at me! It wasn’t my fault! Why did she start crying like that?”

“Because she’s *homesick*, you idiot! And she’s worked too hard putting this party on!”

“Well, how is that *my* fault?”

Revi’s raised voice attracted a few dark looks, but people were more concerned with Erin. Selys stroked Mrsha’s head as the Gnoll clung to Lyonette and buried her face in the girl’s shirt.

“I had no idea Erin was feeling so down. She didn’t say anything to me, and we’re best friends!”

“I say it’s all the work she’s been doing. Halrac is right—she needs a rest. And a friend. We should see if she wants to talk when she gets back.”

Ceria put her head in her hands as she sat at a table with Yvlon, Ksmvr, and the Halfseekers. She felt her own eyes stinging and brushed angrily at them.

“We should have been helping out and keeping her company instead of drinking and doing nothing! We should take tomorrow off and—just be there with her.”

Yvlon and Ksmvr agreed to the idea and Ceria saw other people nodding in agreement around the room. But it was Relc of all people who stared at the ceiling and shook his head.

“Naw, that’s stupid.”

“What?”

Ceria turned and glared at him. The Drake sighed. He looked older as he sat in a chair and leaned back.

“You know what we should do? We should leave her alone. If anyone stays here, she’ll just look after *them*. That’s what she does. Look after

people. She's a weird Human like that."

The half-Elf opened her mouth to retort angrily, and then closed it. At his table, Ulrien nodded.

"That's true. If we're here, she has a job. We're her customers, not just her friends. I say tomorrow, we all go into the city and give her the space she needs. We eat, and sleep there if we can manage it."

"Ulrien!"

Revi protested. He looked hard at her.

"It's what's right, Revi. We won't have a problem occupying ourselves for one day. And in the meantime, anyone who wants to talk with Erin can. But I think the Drake's right. Giving Erin time alone is what she needs."

"My name's Relc, asshole."

The other guests of Erin's inn were in agreement. Selys was still very upset, though. She paced back and forth in front of her table.

"I just—I don't know what to tell Erin! She wants to go home? Where's she from? Terandria? Baleros? Chandrar? She's never talked about it once!"

She looked at Krshia.

"Where's Erin from? Has she told you?"

The Gnoll shifted, and looked around the room. Brunkr, who'd put his head down, raised it warily. Krshia nodded at the door.

"I have some knowledge of her home, but it is not for me to say, no. I am sorry, Selys. But Erin is a girl of many secrets. Her home is one of them, and few know of it."

"Some know. Or have guessed."

Ceria folded her arms frowning at the door as well. She was talking about Pisces, whom she was sure knew more than her.

"How hard is it to find out? Erin's got to have said something to someone. Why's going back so hard? Does she not have enough coin to pay her way home? Is she an outcast? What?"

Wesle's face was filled with honest confusion. He looked around.

"I mean, she's never spoken to me about it. But where's her home?"

No one knew. And those that did weren't saying. Yvlon sat with some of the others, frowning as they talked it over.

"She didn't know about Terandrian nations. And she's not from Chandrar."

"Are you certain?"

Olesm nodded. He was toying with a chess piece, tail twitching with emotion.

“Yeah. She didn’t know about the King of Destruction.”

Yvlon shook her head.

“What, him waking up? That’s big news, but—”

“No, she didn’t know about the King of Destruction *at all*.”

“You’re kidding. Then is she from Baleros?”

“Hardly. Remember Gazi? She told me she’d never met a Gazer before in her life! She thought Gazi was a full Gazer, not a half-Gazer!”

Jelaqua walked over, suddenly alert. She stared at the others.

“Wait, Gazi? You mean, *Gazi the Omniscient*? That monster? How does a girl like Erin know *her*?”

“She poked Gazi’s eye out.”

“She *what*?”

Amid the second uproar, Halrac ground his teeth. He grabbed the wooden spoon Erin had dropped and *snapped* it with a twist of his hands. The sound of breaking wood echoed through the room like a gunshot. Everyone stared at the [Scout]. Halrac’s face was red and he looked angrier than anyone but Ulrien had ever seen him.

“None of this is helpful. So Erin doesn’t seem like she’s from one of the four main continents. So *where* did she come from?”

“The same place as Ryoka Griffin.”

Ceria spoke quietly, tracing a pattern in the spilled ale on one of the tables and freezing the liquid with the tip of her skeletal finger. Everyone fell silent at this. Those who didn’t know Ryoka asked who she was and got varied responses.

Someone else reacted strongly to Ryoka’s name. Zel’s head turned ever so slightly. But he said not a word as he leaned against the kitchen doorframe. Only Mrsha saw his entire body *tense* and the claws on his feet dig into the floorboards.

“Hold on, if Erin’s from the same place as that Runner chick, she *can’t* be nearby. There’s no one who looks like her in Izril, I’m certain.”

Relc scratched the spines on his head as he frowned. Yvlon nodded.

“She’s an islander. From far across the seas, I thought. Is Erin from there?”

“No, she can’t be! She never mentioned getting on a ship to me when we met.”

All eyes were on Relc. Standing against the far wall, Klbkch stared at his partner as Relc tried to puzzle out Erin's origins out loud.

"You see, Klb and I, we were the first people who met her. In this inn. Well, not *this* inn, but the old one. We saw smoke coming out of the chimney one day while we were on patrol. We came to investigate whether bandits or fugitives were hiding out here, and found...her. Just living here."

"You didn't ask how she came here?"

Ceria stared incredulously at Relc. He raised his claws.

"It wasn't our business! She said it might have been a teleportation spell, but she wasn't *actually* sure how she ended up around Liscor. Besides, none of the [Mages] detected any magic that night when we asked them, so I thought she was mistaken. That's as far as we looked into it."

"That's *all* you did?"

"We were busy! She wasn't a wanted criminal anywhere—and believe me, the Captain had us check. She was just some strange Human who came here out of nowhere. Funny thing, though..."

The Drake paused and scratched at his chin.

"She can't have come from the south. It's way too dangerous for someone who's not a Runner or warrior to travel alone, and Erin didn't have any potions or weapons on her. And if she'd come down the northern road someone would have mentioned her, right? I remember traffic was good that day, but no one talked about a girl like her when we asked if they'd seen her."

"So what?"

"So...I don't get how she got here. Liscor's surrounded by mountains. Really *big* mountains. There's no way she could climb the High Passes, not with no levels...wait, she did say she was from some place. Hold on. What was it called?"

Everyone waited. Relc scratched his head.

"What was the place called? Michi...Missia...hm. Nope. I don't recall."

Expectant breaths were released. The listeners shook their heads as Relc shrugged helplessly.

"No levels?"

Typhenous frowned. Relc nodded absently.

"Yeah. She only had like four levels in [Innkeeper]. But nothing else. That's what she said."

"Strange."

“You’re telling me. Wait, now I remember...Erin said she ran away from something. Oh yeah, she said she ran away from a *Dragon* when she got here. I remember thinking how crazy she was!”

“A Dragon?”

The room stirred. Jasi exchanged a wide-eyed glance with the other Humans from Celum. Olesm and the other Drakes looked just as incredulous as Relc.

“There’s no way.”

“Right, I mean, that’s what Klb and I thought. She must have run from a Wyvern, right? Only, her arm was burned. A fire breathing Wyvern, I guess.”

“I find it hard to believe that girl would confuse a Wyvern with a Dragon.”

Seborn nodded to the door. Relc shrugged.

“Come on, it can’t have been a *Dragon*. She probably just thought it was because she’d never seen a Wyvern before.”

“If it was a Wyvern, why didn’t it run her down?”

Halrac stared at a scar on his arm. Ulrien nodded as everyone turned towards their table.

“Wyverns are fast hunters. They don’t give up on their prey. Even if she was running at night, it would have swooped down on her. Unless she had tree cover, and the area around Liscor has virtually no trees.”

“Except the ones that go ‘boom’. Yeah. Okay. But—nah, it was probably a huge salamander. That breathes fire. It’s not a Dragon, right Klbkch?”

Relc turned towards Klbkch. The Antinium was silent for a moment as every eye fell on him. Then he nodded.

“The odds of a Dragon living near Liscor are remote. It is highly unlikely it was a Dragon that Erin saw.”

“Right, there was no Dragon.”

“That is a reasonable assumption, yes.”

The Drake [Guardsmen] nodded. He turned back to the others.

“The only reason I’m mentioning it, see, is because Erin said she was running away from that. So she might have come from...Esthelm? Only she didn’t know that city...damn. If it was a Dragon, it could have teleported her, since Dragons can do all kinds of things like that, right? But if it wasn’t a Dragon...did she say she was ever on a ship...? Let me think.”

The others kept conferring. But sitting at his table with Jasi, Grev wiped at his face and then stared at Klbkch. He looked back at the others, and then raised his hand.

“Hey.”

No one heard him. Grev hesitated, and then called out.

“Hey!”

All the adults turned to look at him. Some, like Halrac, were annoyed. Grev quailed, but he said his bit determinedly as he pointed to Klbkch.

“He never said there were no Dragons. That Ant man.”

“What? Grev, don’t interrupt—”

“No, wait. What did you say?”

Zel raised his claw and came away from the kitchen’s entrance. He stared at Grev. The boy gulped, but went on, stammering as everyone looked at him.

“He—it’s a trick, see? In the city. You learn to listen for it. If someone don’t say something’s true or not true, they’re not lying, see? But they’re still not saying if it’s true or not. That K—Kb—that guy said it weren’t *likely* Dragons were around Liscor. But he never said they wasn’t.”

The room grew very, very quiet. All heads turned to Klbkch. He sat next to Xrn, the overturned table at his feet. The blue Antinium was staring at Klbkch. But the Antinium said nothing.

“Hah! There are no Dragons. Tell him, Klbkch!”

Relc laughed nervously as he stared at his partner. Klbkch said nothing. Krshia cleared her throat with a rumble.

“Why do you say nothing, Klbkch? Is it as the Human child says? We have Skills, yes. Skills to detect lying among those in this room. Say there are no Dragons and we shall know. Unless you are a deceiver of the highest level.”

Still, Klbkch said nothing. Relc lost his nervous grin. Ceria felt her heart begin to beat faster.

“Klb? Hey, buddy...”

There was no way for Klbkch to get out of it. Even Pawn and the other Antinium were staring at him. At last, Klbkch nodded and looked around the room coldly.

“Regrettable. I will say nothing on this matter.”

That was all. But his words were confirmation enough.

“Dead gods!”

Typhenous knocked his chair back. Halrac's hand had gone white on his mug. Ulrien was staring. The Halfseekers seemed paralyzed. Ceria felt like her heart was about to beat out of her chest.

And those who weren't adventurers were stunned. Selys gaped at Klbkch. She whispered a word.

"Ancestors."

Zel felt his heart beating faster than he could ever remember. He stared at Klbkch. A Dragon. Could it be? He saw Relc's mouth hanging open and Olesm, scales white as a sheet. The Ancestors, the First Parents. How long had it been since a Dragon had been seen on Izril—no, anywhere in the world?

Chance sightings. Stolen cattle, or strange burn marks. That was the rumor. But a real Dragon sighting? A Dragon? Here?

He couldn't believe it. No one could. But the Antinium who knew the truth had confirmed it by not denying it. Or had he? Was it just a trick that played on the faintest possibility? Zel's eyes narrowed as he stared at Klbkch.

The Antinium was unmoved. He stared around the room, at the eyes on him and the countless unanswered questions on everyone's tongue. And it was clear he meant to answer none of them.

"Regardless of what you may believe, it is not in the best interests of my Hive for me to reveal any information confirming or denying your suspicions. I bear many of you no ill will, but I do not see you as comrades either. Erin Solstice I consider my friend, but her friends are not mine. You are all dust."

His expressionless face was turned towards the place where Revi stood. Or perhaps it was Zel he was staring at.

The [General] moved forwards slowly. The people in the center of the room backed away as he walked to face Klbkch. Zel was standing straight, and there was the same hostility in his gaze as when he'd first laid eyes on Klbkch.

"If there is a Dragon on the continent, I think we should know about it."

"Oh? I was not aware I answered to you."

Klbkch slowly stood up from his chair. He seemed—angry. That was what Relc noticed. It wasn't a word he'd ever had to use to describe his friend. But he saw it in the way Klbkch stood, and the way his hands hovered close to his swords.

“Hey, Klb, buddy. Hold on, you’re talking to a real hero here. General Shivertail—excuse my friend. Klbkch, come on. I served with General Zel during the war. He’s practically a pal...”

“He is not my friend. He killed two of the beings I called friend. Two of my comrades fell at his claws, never to rise again.”

Klbkch stared at Zel. The Drake felt the electric bond of hatred surging between them. He nodded, uncurling his fists into claws at his side.

“I fought against you in the war, Klbkch the Slayer. And as far as I’m concerned, the war never ended. Not with the Antinium. Your kind don’t know peace. So if you’re plotting something with a *Dragon*—”

“What my kind does is our affair, Zel Shivertail. It may be there is no Dragon and that I am simply tricking you. As I recall, you fell quite easily for such tricks during the war.”

That was it. Zel felt a spark ignite something in his breast. He took a step—

And a shadow fell over him. Zel turned his head and saw Moore, head in the rafters, standing on his right. Jelaqua was on his left, and the tingling on the scales of Zel’s neck told him the [Rogue], Seborn, was right behind him.

“Hey, not that I don’t like a fight, but if there is one I’d prefer the civilians and kids to be out of the room first, okay?”

Jelaqua smiled at everyone as she put a hand on her belt. She didn’t have her two-handed flail with her, but she had a dagger at her side.

Someone else stepped between Zel and Klbkch. Halrac and Ulrien stood in front of Typhenous and Revi. The two mages looked nervous, but Revi had something in her hands and Typhenous was staring fixedly at Klbkch.

“Halrac and I fought in the Antinium wars.”

Ulrien stared placidly at Klbkch, speaking calmly, but in such a way that it was clear he was ready to do violence. His face was unreadable, but emotion flickered in his tone, out of sight. He glanced at Zel as well.

“I fought against Antinium. But I also fought against Drakes every time their armies came up through Liscor. As far as I’m concerned, you two are welcome to tear each other apart—elsewhere.”

Zel didn’t move. He knew the Gold-rank adventurers had numbers and the drop on him if he moved. But he also knew he didn’t care. And from the way Klbkch was staring at him, the Antinium didn’t care either.

The room was frozen. Selys, staring at the two, bent down to whisper to Lyonette. The girl jerked as Selys touched her and pointed.

“Go over there. If Uncle Zel gets angry, you want to be behind him as far as you can go. If he loses his temper, no one in this room will be able to stop him.”

She whispered a bit too loudly. The Gold-rank adventurers in the room shifted uncomfortably. A Drake [General], a famous one like Zel Shivertail, was at least the equivalent of a Named Adventurer.

“Not true.”

It was Xrn of all people who spoke in answer to Selys. The blue Antinium stood up casually, ignoring the way people shifted their attention towards them. She stared at Zel and then at Selys.

“You may not know me, young Drake. But I am Xrn, the Small Queen. Of all those who fought in the Antinium Wars, I was the one who never fell. I am strongest in this room, and so it is I who say: enough.”

She turned to Klbkch.

“Klbkchhezeim. Klbkch the Slayer. You will honor the peace. Or I will halt you myself. As for you, Zel Shivertail...”

She turned to Zel as Klbkch abruptly sat down and folded his arms. Zel stared at Xrn with as much enmity as Klbkch, but the Antinium appeared not to feel his contained fury.

“You are quite different from what I expected. Was it luck or fate that kept us from ever meeting each other on the battlefield during two wars? In any case, I am surprised by you. There is not much of General Sserys in the way you act. He was far more cautious, for all his daring.”

Zel recoiled as if he was struck. The silent room drew in a breath as one. Looking worried, the Gold-rank adventurers stepped away from Zel. There was death in his eyes as he spoke.

“Watch your tongue. Sserys was my mentor. My friend. I haven’t forgotten that you killed him.”

“No. You would not. But did you know, Zel Shivertail? I was there when he died. I spoke to him in the minutes before his death.”

Not a word. Not a breath was drawn. Every eye was on these two. Zel stared at Xrn, and knew that if she spoke the wrong word it would be her head he held next, or his smoking body that lay on the ground. He didn’t care about the consequences. One wrong word.

And it would be war.

“What did you say to him?”

“Many things. Things that I will not utter here. But know that I did not kill him, Zel Shivertail.”

The Drake spat. Xrn shook her head.

“There are others in this room who know I am speaking the truth. I did not kill Sserys. Now. Would you like to know who did?”

Zel’s heart stopped. He stared at Xrn.

“Who?”

“It was no soldier. No common warrior of the Hives. Of course, you knew that. A single thrust to the heart.”

The Small Queen stared around the room. Her eyes returned to Zel, and her mandibles opened.

“Three Prognugators, three of the *original* Prognugators survived the war. You named us. Each one. Klbkch the Slayer. I, Xrn. The Small Queen. And the last...”

“Wrymvr. The Deathless.”

Xrn nodded slightly.

“Just so. Ask him what became of Sserys if you are so inclined.”

Something was burning hot in Zel’s chest. He took a step and the room tensed. But he staggered towards the door. Zel pushed it open and disappeared into the snowstorm. He didn’t feel the cold. He didn’t feel anything, but the beating of his heart. He heard the word in his mind, like a pulse thumping in his chest.

Wrymvr the Deathless.

When he was gone, Xrn turned to the speechless room. She smiled, opening her mandibles as the swirling lights in her eyes lightened and turned bright orange.

“Well, I have done one of the things I have come here to do. Klbkch, we shall speak now. Or perhaps after your presents are opened. Erin Solstice returns.”

All heads turned towards the door. After a few seconds, it was pushed open. Erin walked into the inn, no longer crying. She smiled cheerfully at everyone.

“I’m so sorry guys. I don’t know what happened. I can’t apologize enough, but—”

She paused and stared at the overturned table, at the people gathered together, the tense adventurers, and the stunned looks on most of her guests.

“Uh. What happened?”

After that came presents. It seemed like almost a letdown after all that had passed, but no one had told Erin what had happened and she was determined to salvage the party.

“Here you are, Klbkch! It’s from me!”

The Antinium took the present gingerly, ignoring the stares coming his way. He unwrapped the gift and found...

“A scarf.”

It was black, with splashes of red along the ends. Klbkch stared at the scarf as Erin smiled nervously.

“I had it specially knit. Jasi knows a good [Seamstress], and, well, I thought it would look good on you! I know the Antinium don’t have possessions, but I thought you could wear it now and then...”

Klbkch looked at Erin. Without a word he wound it around his neck. The scarf’s red ends dangled around his shoulders.

“I appreciate it deeply, Erin.”

“Ooh, is that for me? What did I—food!”

Relc goggled at his present. Erin laughed as he lifted out the huge jar of what were to him, strange, round, golden-brown circles.

“They’re cookies! Honey cookies, extra sugary, Relc! Ever since Octavia helped me make baking powder, I’ve been *dying* to make some!”

“Are they—are they all...?”

“All for you! Go on! Try one!”

Relc did. He bit into the chewy, thick cookie and teared up. He hugged Erin tightly, making her yelp as he scarfed down another cookie.

“They’re so good! So good! So *sweet*!”

Everyone had presents, and everyone opened them, with the exception of the absent Zel and Xrn, whom Erin hadn’t included on the list. They opened presents, at first awkwardly, but soon getting over the excitement of the last few minutes for a more normal, fun experience.

“A new robe?”

Pisces stared incredulously at Ceria. He held up the pristine white robes, made of strong, soft cotton. She smiled wryly at him.

“Don’t go crying on *my* shoulder. Erin insisted I get something for you—hold on Ksmvr. Is this for me?”

“I have obtained the present for you, yes, Captain Springwalker.”

Ceria frowned as she opened the present.

“What is—”

She gasped and Pisces’ eyes nearly fell out of his head as he stared at the lump of gold. Ceria gaped at the gold nugget and then at Ksmvr. He nodded in satisfaction.

“I was advised to get jewelry for you by Erin Solstice. Gold is a component of jewelry, hence this gift is appropriate. Do you like it?”

“Um. Yes!”

Other presents weren’t as dramatic. Lyonette was explaining to Halrac that the jar of honey and sausage was a gift from Mrsha—the Gnoll had picked out the sausage herself. Brunkr blinked down at the bottle of wine Wesle had given him and the [Actor] introduced himself awkwardly as he clutched the blanket Jasi had bought for him around his shoulders.

Relc had bought a wickedly sharp curved dagger that [Assassins] used for Klbkch. The Antinium had bought him a signed receipt from every tavern owner in the city, promising Relc ten free drinks.

“You guys are so sweet!”

Jelaqua laughed as she accepted her gifts from Seborn and Moore. Respectively they were a powdering kit to make her body look more alive, and an extra-powerful liquid soap bought from Octavia.

When Erin asked what the soap was for, Jelaqua winked at her.

“Helps with cleaning all the parts that get really messy. You know how it is.”

The girl shuddered. But then she laughed, and gave Jelaqua a hug, much to the Selphid’s delight.

It was Christmas. In time, people began looking towards their beds. The adventurers trooped upstairs, and the others bid Erin goodnight.

“They’ll all be heading out tomorrow. But if you want to talk—”

Selys gripped Erin’s hands gently with her claws. Erin didn’t quite meet her eyes as she smiled.

“I’ll be fine, Selys. I’m sorry about—well, merry Christmas.”

“Yeah. Have a good one. This was really fun, Erin.”

The others passed by Erin, nodding to her, shaking her hand, hugging her—Klbkch paused as Xrn stood by his side.

“I apologize for causing a commotion in your absence, Erin.”

“Oh? Uh, well, you’re forgiven.”

Erin blinked as he bowed his head and left. She stared as Klbkch walked out into the snow with Xrn.

The two Antinium moved in silence, and then Xrn looked at Klbkch.

“Do you understand what I did in there, Klbkch?”

“I understand, but I do not know *why*.”

Klbkch stared at Xrn. The Small Queen sighed.

“Had we talked, you would know. But understand this, Klbkch. I did not come here to simply evaluate your Hive’s latest works. There is more at stake here.”

Klbkch hesitated.

“Then it seems we must talk after all. I feared what you might say. Now I do not know what you have come here to tell me.”

“Well then. Let us find out.”

They walked off towards their Hive.

Back at the inn, Halrac, Revi, Typhenous, and Ulrien stood together in the hallway as Erin bade the last of her guests goodnight, speaking quietly.

“We’ll leave tomorrow, then. Halrac, are you sure this is what you want to do?”

“Ask, Ulrien.”

The [Scout] stood with arms folded. He stared down towards the staircase. He could still hear Erin saying goodbye to Octavia.

“There’s something about her. Just ask your contacts and I’ll ask mine. That’s all I want.”

“Who *is* that girl?”

Revi stared at her teammates. No one answered. Ulrien yawned, and looked to his room.

“We may find an answer tomorrow. Until then...Merry Christmas.”

“Yeah.”

“I suppose?”

“Merry Christmas to you all.”

Halrac and Revi went to their rooms. Typhenous bade them goodnight. He paused at the doorway, and turned to make sure the corridor was empty.

Then he smiled and put a finger to his head. He whispered as he entered his room.

“[Message] spell to Lord Tyrion Veltras. Please record the following message and deliver at once. Yes...I will pay for immediate priority delivery.”

He spoke a short message as he closed the door to his room. No one heard. Or rather, Typhenous *thought* that no one heard.

Pisces shook his head as he cancelled the [Invisibility] spell and walked silently down the stairs towards the basement. Mages. It was the same in Wistram—despite knowing such powerful magics, even the best mages were so *careless*. How hard would it have been to put up a [Muffle] spell, or a [Contained Sound] ward? He could just put his ear to the door and listen!

“What the hell were you doing up there?”

Ceria hissed at Pisces as she and the other Horns of Hammerad stood at the door to the basement. Pisces flicked his fingers and the specialized magic only she could read flickered before her eyes.

Tell you later. Much is afoot.

She stared at him, and then yanked the trapdoor open. Yvlon and Ksmvr went down below.

“Erin? We’re going to sleep. Goodnight.”

“Oh. Goodnight!”

Erin turned and smiled at the Horns of Hammerad. Ceria nodded to her, searching the Human girl’s face. But Erin seemed cheerful, if tired.

The half-Elf and Pisces went down below. Erin turned and saw Lyonette and Mrsha standing on the stairwell.

“Do you need anything else, Erin?”

“No, I think we can clean up tomorrow. You two have a good night. Merry Christmas!”

Mrsha made a small, indistinct, sleepy noise and Lyonette smiled.

“Merry Christmas, Erin.”

And then she went upstairs. Erin stood in the center of her messy room, smiling faintly. She noticed coins on the tables and frowned. Apparently, people still paid her for the party.

She went around from table to table, collecting coins. As she did, Erin mechanically piled up dishes. When she got to the overturned table, she stopped.

Slowly, Erin looked around the dark room. The only light now came from the fireplace. Erin went over to it and stared at the embers. They glowed in the darkness, but dimly. They were fading, without any fuel left to consume.

She looked around again. No one. Erin was sure everyone was asleep by now. So she sat by the fire and stared into the remains.

“I really screwed up, didn’t I?”

Erin said it softly, not wanting to wake anyone. How could she have done that? Broken down in front of everyone? On Christmas?

Her hands trembled. Now that she was alone, really alone, Erin felt her eyes stinging again. She’d ruined Christmas. Even if people were happy now, she’d made them all sad. Because she was sad.

But she *was* sad! Erin stared at the blurry orange light and wiped at her eyes. Her shoulders began to shake.

Standing at the top of the stairs, Lyonette made not a noise. She stared down into the dark room, at the figure sitting by the fire. She heard the muffled sounds, almost indistinct in the quiet inn. And then Erin’s voice.

She was crying again. When no one could see. Lyonette leaned against the bannister as she heard Erin’s voice.

“I want to go *home!*”

Erin wept uncontrollably as she sat alone by the dying fire. Hidden in the shadows, Lyonette stared down at Erin. She reached a hand out, and then turned away.

There were tears in Lyonette’s eyes as she went into her and Mrsha’s room, closing the door softly behind her. She stared out her window up at the clear night sky. She cried too. Not for herself, but for Erin. For a girl that wanted to go home.

Her voice was a whisper. Lyonette stared up at the dark sky. There was no one to hear her, but she spoke anyway. She spoke to the world and the stars.

“I, Lyonette du Marquin, swear on my name. I swear by my blood. Someday I will...”

In her inn, Erin curled up on the floor. She kept crying, letting loose all the emotions she’d kept bottled up for so long. She lay on the ground as the day she’d called Christmas ended. The longest night began as Erin slept on the floor of her inn, eyes red, curled up by a dead fire.

The shortest day of the year began as Erin Solstice slept. Her friends stayed in the city, left her to her grief. Erin was alone.
Alone.

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Interlude

The day after Christmas, Ryoka woke up in a quiet village where the houses were still partly submerged by snow. She got up and after eating a communal breakfast with the villagers, began to say her goodbyes.

“Are you sure you won’t stay, Miss Ryoka? There’s hardly a road to follow, and the snow hasn’t stopped falling. We’d be happy to offer you a place to stay as long as is needed.”

Prost indicated one of the excavated houses they’d let Ryoka stay in for the night. Ryoka, thinking of how she’d been the only person to have a room to herself while the others slept four or more to a room, shook her head.

“It’s kind of you to offer, but I have to be going. I can reach Invril in a day even with deep snow. I have a...guide.”

“Just as you say, Miss. But I...we...can’t thank you enough for making this delivery on Emperor Laken’s behalf.”

He took Ryoka’s hand in his callused ones and bowed over it. Ryoka hesitated, and then clasped Prost’s hand.

“It was the right thing to do, that’s all. Your [Emperor] is a good man. He was the one who convinced me to make the journey. Thank him as well. But I have to be off. There’s somewhere I need to go back to, and people waiting for me. Perhaps I’ll return in the future.”

“If you do, our doors will always be open to you. Always. We owe you a large debt, Miss Ryoka.”

That promise was repeated by every man and woman Ryoka said farewell to. Every villager wanted to say goodbye to Ryoka personally, and she had to shake their hands, trade hugs...and also bend down to do the same to the children.

“You take it easy, okay?”

Ryoka looked Anabelle in the eyes as the young girl reached out to shake her hand. The child was still holding the doll that Ryoka had given her. She hadn’t let go of it once.

“I will, Miss. Thank you.”

She looked so small, standing in the freshly fallen snow. Ryoka felt old as she stood and put her gloves on. The wind blew and she nearly lost her

grip on one.

“It’s cold. You stay warm and indoors, alright? When the snows melt... Laken will return.”

“I know he will. He promised.”

Anabelle smiled. There was such trust in her expression that Ryoka didn’t know what to say. She looked down at the girl and then at the village.

“You all really love him, don’t you?”

“He saved us, Miss Runner. You did, too. Maybe when I gain a class, I’ll be a [Runner].”

Ryoka glanced down and opened her mouth. She hesitated, looking into Anabelle’s eyes. They were alight, not dull and empty like they had been when she’d first seen them. Ryoka bit back what she was about to say, and knelt one last time.

“You know what? You might be a good [Runner]. When spring comes, eat a lot and run around a bit. Just have fun, and...we’ll see. Until then, stay warm.”

She stood, and turned. It was time to go. The villagers who’d gathered around her in the cold stepped back. But one woman came hurrying towards Ryoka, holding a box in her hands.

It was one of the present boxes Ryoka had handed out last night. Only, this one had been rewrapped in a hurry. Ryoka stared at it and then raised her hands.

“Oh no. You didn’t...please, I don’t need anything. I can’t accept—”

“It’s Christmas, isn’t it? And you gave us so much...please, take this.”

The woman, Prost’s wife, Yesel, handed the box to Ryoka. The girl wanted to refuse, but couldn’t. She gingerly unwrapped the gift and blinked down at what was inside.

It was a scarf. Hand-knitted, thick, it was dark grey, but for a band of blue across the center. The scarf had a complex wave-pattern that saw the blue center rise and fall, like a wave. It looked brand new, and as if it had never been used.

Ryoka took the wool scarf out of the box and stared at Yesel. The woman looked at her, looked at the scarf, and Ryoka knew that it had not been meant for her. But she asked no questions.

It was useful, but Ryoka didn’t want to take it. She was on the verge of refusing when she suddenly glanced up and to the left. Yesel stared, but

Ryoka only seemed to be staring at a patch of blank air to her. But then the girl looked down at her and tried to force a smile.

“Thank you. I—I guess I would need this, after all.”

“It’s far too cold to be without. And it’s—a good fit. I’d be happier seeing it on you than going to waste.”

Yesel watched as Ryoka wound the scarf around her face and neck. Normally Ryoka wouldn’t have bothered, but her coat didn’t cover her head, and the wind was freezing. Any colder and Ryoka wouldn’t be able to stay outdoors without goggles or some kind of protection to keep her corneas from freezing. She’d heard of that happening and had no desire to find out what that felt like herself.

“Thank you. When I see Lak—your [Emperor], I’ll let him know you’re all well.”

Ryoka said it again as she walked towards the outskirts of the village. The people gathered and waved after her, calling blessings. Ryoka slowly began to jog, and then run out of the village. She didn’t look back once, and soon, she’d left it behind.

When Ryoka was certain she was out of sight, she slowed her pace a bit. She spoke to the air.

“Ivolethe. Why did you tell me to accept the scarf?”

The Frost Faerie flew down out of the air and hovered by Ryoka’s side as the girl ran on through the deep snow. It was flurrying, the snow blowing down and confusing any sense of direction. It would soon be very dark, Ryoka knew. Only Ivolethe’s light shone brightly in this world of frost and snow.

“Refusing a gift given in good will on the Winter Solstice is ill luck, Ryoka. You should know that.”

“Really?”

Ryoka frowned at Ivolethe. She’d forgotten it was the shortest day of the year today. But then, it made sense. Yesterday hadn’t actually been Christmas, just a day that Erin had chosen to be the holiday. And the Winter Solstice...

“Does that mean the winter’s only half-over?”

Ivolethe shook her head.

“Nay, two thirds. I do not know how such things are reckoned where you hail from, but in this place, we govern winter. And the shortest day of the year marks the beginning of the end. In time, we shall depart. But this day has more significance than just that. That is why I warned you not to scorn the gift of goodwill.”

“Why? Because it’s unlucky?”

“Yes.”

Ryoka laughed. But Ivolethe’s face remained serious as she flew next to the girl.

“Do not mock my words. It is the Winter Solstice, Ryoka Griffin. Not Christmas. Not some day of mortal make. There is power in this day, even if it is not celebrated by the races of this world.”

The smile on Ryoka’s face faded. She stared at Ivolethe.

“You’re serious. What, is the Winter Solstice really an important day here?”

The Frost Faerie nodded.

“Today is a day of power. It is the shortest day of the year—a moment when spirits and magic mix and mingle with the mortal plane. Surely you know of this?”

“I—not really. You’re telling me magic is stronger on this day?”

“Perhaps. Perhaps not. I would not know, since magic is practiced differently by the people of this world. But other things take on different aspects on this day.”

“Hold up.”

Ryoka slowed down and stopped in the deep snow. She brushed some snowflakes away from her face and stared at Ivolethe.

“Are you telling me that days like the Winter Solstice, the equinoxes, things like the witching hour...are all actual times of power?”

The Frost Faerie flew closer to Ryoka's face. There was not a twitch, not a single tell that she was lying or playing games. She looked as serious as Ryoka had ever seen her, and that bothered the young woman greatly.

"Time has power, as does place. I say again, be cautious today, Ryoka Griffin. Since you travel, it would be best if you enter no house uninvited nor ask for any favors of those you meet upon the road. Utter no curses, ask for no blessings if ye are unwilling to pay the price. And make no bargains, make no promises. Tell no lies."

Ryoka stared at Ivolethe. Her humor faded, and she felt just the tiniest bit uneasy.

"I will. But if today's so important—no, dangerous—would it have been better to stay indoors?"

The faerie shook her head. She cast her eyes upwards at the dark sky and the falling snow.

"Indoors? Hah. On such a day, only a leyline or—nae, a sacred spot would attract attention. Fate will find you no matter where you go, Ryoka. Best to be about your business. But let us hurry on. It will be dark soon, and you should be behind stone and iron before the night is deepest."

She flew ahead, lighting Ryoka's path. The girl ran after her. On the shortest day of the year, she followed the Frost Faerie onwards. But soon, both Ryoka and Ivolethe were lost. And dusk came quickly, so that when Erin woke, in the blink of an eye it seemed almost like night.

Erin Solstice woke up late in the day for once. But when she sat up, letting the blanket fall off her shoulders by the smoldering fireplace, she thought she was dreaming.

It was already dusk, and her inn was empty. Erin stared at the blanket someone had wrapped around her, and then looked around her inn. But from the basement to the second floor, there was not a soul to be found.

Even Lyonette's bee grub was gone. Her inn was deserted. No one was here, but Erin.

The girl walked about, feeling a wave of loneliness pass over her. It was the same feeling as yesterday. As every day, really.

She was alone. Only now she didn't have anything to keep her busy.

Erin didn't eat. She went over to the fireplace and sat in front of it, staring into the embers. Someone had added fuel to the fire, but it had burnt low again by the time Erin had woke up.

The girl stared into the fading coals, and then reached for a piece of wood. She slowly placed the log onto the fire, and watched the wood smoulder and then begin to ignite. She put a second piece of wood next to the first, and the fire grew. It reached up to consume the logs, and the wood burned.

The room began to warm. Erin huddled in front of the fire, warming herself. She stared into the heart of the flames and felt the inn echo around her. Vast. Empty.

On the hill, her inn stood, windows shuttered, door closed. It was the one building around. The city lay a small ways off, no doubt full of life. And beyond that, a few villages filled the hilltops before the snowy floodplains gave way to higher ground. Past that was the city of Esthelm, and other lands.

But here, on this isolated hilltop, the inn was the only source of light and life, however faint it may be. And in that inn, a young woman held her hands to the fire. She added more wood, and the modest blaze became a large conflagration, burning bright and fierce.

It was a waste of firewood for one person. But Erin didn't care. She stoked the fire, feeding it, making it large enough to warm her cold heart and tired body. And the fire grew, and the inn warmed and gained new life.

So Erin sat, warming herself and thinking of nothing in front of the fire. She would have sat there until she slept, but then she heard a sound. She turned, and realized she had visitors.

Three.

They were lost. Ryoka didn't realize it at first. She followed Ivolethe, never doubting the faerie...until she found herself running past a fallen tree that looked too familiar to ignore.

"Ivolethe!"

Ryoka pulled down the scarf around her face, grimacing and wiping at the moisture built up on her lips and nose by her breath. Snow blew past her as Ryoka covered her face with one arm, shielding it from the worst of the blizzard. It felt just as bad—no, worse—than yesterday.

“*Ivolethe!* Where the hell are we!? I could have sworn we passed that same tree a minute ago!”

She had to look hard to see the Frost Faerie’s glow as Ivolethe flew back towards her. Ivolethe was frowning as she stared at the fallen tree Ryoka pointed to.

“It is not the same tree. Your eyes play tricks on you, Ryoka Griffin.”

“You sure?”

Ryoka peered at the tree. She hadn’t paid much attention to it, but she felt it was lying in the same place and at the same angle as the last one she’d seen. How many fallen trees were there, anyways?

“Where are we going, Ivolethe? I thought we were following the road!”

“We are!”

“What do you call *this*, then?”

Ryoka waved her hand at the grove of trees that she and the Frost Faerie were travelling through. It was a forest of some kind, and not one Ryoka remembered going through on the way to Riverfarm.

Ivolethe looked uncertain. She cast about and flew upwards, fighting the strong winds that threatened to blow her away. When she flew back down to Ryoka, she pointed past the tree.

“This is the way to the road.”

The young woman peered doubtfully in the direction Ivolethe had indicated.

“You sure?”

“Yes! Now come!”

Ivolethe scowled, unused to being questioned. She flew off angrily and Ryoka cursed and ran to catch up, wrapping her scarf around her head as she did.

“Don’t go so fast, Ivolethe! I can barely see you in all of this! Can’t you make your light red again?”

The faerie didn’t answer, or maybe she didn’t hear Ryoka. The girl ran on, tripping over buried tree roots and cursing as she passed through a spot with low-hanging branches. But then she saw the faint light of Ivolethe’s aura pause. Ryoka caught up to the faerie and halted.

“What the...”

They were back at the fallen tree. Only this time, they were facing it from an entirely different angle. Ryoka turned back and stared the way they’d come. Then she looked angrily at Ivolethe.

“What the hell is this, Ivolethe? Are you messing with me?”

“I’m not!”

The faerie protested as Ryoka glared at her. She stared at the fallen tree, her brows furrowed.

“I...must have turned the wrong way. But I will take you to the road. It’s this way.”

She pointed in a completely different direction than the way she had before. Ryoka stared at Ivolethe, frowning with vexation.

“If you’re playing games, Ivolethe, I’m not in the mood. I’m cold—it’s getting dark, and—”

“Cease your complaints! I know the way. Follow me and be silent!”

The faerie snapped at Ryoka and flew off. Surprised by the faerie’s outburst—Ivolethe sounded truly angry—Ryoka followed the faerie. But after a few minutes of running she realized something was wrong.

“Ivolethe. *Ivolethe!*”

The faerie paused and glared back at Ryoka.

“What?”

“You’re going the wrong way! You just turned left, towards the way we came!”

“I did not!”

“You did. I saw you! Look—you can see the fallen tree back that way!”

Ryoka pointed, and Ivolethe stared incredulously. It was true. She was headed straight back towards the fallen tree again.

About to make an acidic comment, Ryoka paused as she stared at the Frost Faerie. She’d assumed Ivolethe was playing a prank on her, but the surprise and uncertainty she saw on the tiny faerie’s face bothered her.

“What’s going on, Ivolethe? Why are we going in circles?”

“I...do not know. Hold. I will see where we are. Just wait—”

Ivolethe cast about, and then flew up. Ryoka saw her form flying straight up, and then getting dragged to the left by the wind.

“By the wind...? I thought Ivolethe could read the wind. Or control it.”

Ryoka muttered to herself as she saw Ivolethe fighting to stay in one place. The faerie flew higher, until her light was swallowed up by the darkness. Ryoka waited on the ground for a minute. And then five.

And then ten. Ryoka stared upwards, shivering, calling out.

“*Ivolethe!* Are you there? Answer me!”

But no response came. Ryoka paced back and forth anxiously. After what felt like forever, she saw the faintest of lights in the darkening skies. Ivolethe flew down out of the sky, shouting Ryoka’s name.

“Ryoka! Ryoka Griffin! Hear my call! Where art thou?”

“Here! Ivolethe, I’m here!”

Ryoka shouted and waved her arms. The Frost Faerie flew towards her.

“Where did ye go? I lost you!”

“I didn’t go anywhere! You went straight up and vanished!”

“No! I flew up and when I looked back to find you, you were gone!”

The two stared at each other, searching for a hint of deception in each other’s expressions. But neither was lying. After a second, Ryoka stared around at the scattered trees and dark landscape.

“What’s going on, Ivolethe? I’m being serious, now. I don’t like what’s happening.”

The faerie looked grave. She flew closer to Ryoka and placed a hand on her small chest.

“Upon my name, Ryoka Griffin, I do not know. I am not lying to ye. Something is afoot and I cannot tell what.”

“Could it be...could it be your sisters, Ivolethe? I didn’t see them when I woke up—is this some prank of theirs? Or someone else...of your kind?” Ivolethe frowned and looked about. Then she shook her head.

“I would be able to tell if it were a working of my people. Besides, the magic of the fae is mine. I see through all glamours, and can walk through the twisted halls of my land without losing my way. The magic of the *Sidhe* cannot fool my eyes, any more than a spell of mortal make can. No, this is something else. Something...else.”

That bothered Ryoka greatly. She stared about once more, noting how the sun, still completely hidden behind the clouds, was almost gone. She recalled what Ivolethe had said about the Winter Solstice. A time of power. An important event.

“Look, did you see the road? Can we follow that?”

The faerie looked at Ryoka and slowly shook her head.

“I saw no road, Ryoka.”

“But we just left—”

“I saw no road. Nor any landmarks I recognized. Just trees and snow and darkness.”

Ryoka paused. She felt the wind blow harder, and the chill cut into her flesh. But there was another chill in her bones.

“In that case...we’re lost. And it’s cold. I know you might not feel it, Ivolethe, but if I have to spend the night...I need a fire.”

“I know. And it seems we cannot leave this place yet. Build a fire, Ryoka Griffin, and quickly. Build it high and mighty. I will help.”

The faerie flew past Ryoka, and both girl and fae ran back towards the fallen tree. It was cold, hard as rock, and partially covered by the snow, but it was a good place to start.

Finding a spot that was at least partially protected from the wind, Ryoka set to work trying to build a fire. She used the fallen tree as protection from the wind, and scraped away snow and ice to get to the wet earth below.

There was no hope of building a snow cave out here, despite the deep snow. It was all powder, and Ryoka felt like if she tried to pack it into a buildable substance she’d be working all night. She’d have to dig a trench. At least if she used the tree, she could count on sheltering herself from a good portion of the wind chill.

But first, the fire. Ryoka knew she was very lucky to have burnable, dead wood around her. She took out the knife at her belt that she’d seldom used but always carried, and began hacking at the dead branches of the fallen tree.

She needed dry, burnable fuel to start with. Ivolethe flew out of the storm and dropped more dead wood for the young woman as she stripped bark and the outer layer of frozen wood away, searching for dry wood pulp.

It took Ryoka a long time to set the fire up even when she had enough wood. She didn’t know any fire spells, and the flint and steel she carried were *not* as handy as a ziplocked bag of dry matches. Or a can of petroleum.

“Can’t you unfreeze part of this place? I know you did it once—you have spring powers, right?”

Ryoka shouted at Ivolethe in frustration after her eighth failed attempt to get the tinder to light. The Frost Faerie shook her head as she hovered a few feet away from Ryoka’s attempt at a fire.

“I have such aspects, but it is not wise to use them without dire cause, Ryoka. And even then...nae. Not here.”

She looked around warily at the dark forest. Ryoka paused and stared at Ivolethe. The Frost Faerie stared back. Her expression told Ryoka more than she wanted to know. It was uncertain, and more than that...Ryoka had never seen a faerie looking uneasy.

The girl bent over the wood and redoubled her efforts to get it to light. At last, after Ryoka’s hands were cramping up from striking so many sparks, one caught. Ryoka immediately sheltered the fire, letting it grow, desperately helping Ivolethe feed it bits of tinder.

And after what seemed like hours of work, there was a fire. Ryoka sat back, gasping with relief as it grew and she fed it more wood, letting it warm her and the wet firewood she’d placed around it.

“Thank god. Thank...jeeze.”

Ivolethe flew around the fire, dropping bits of dry wood into it. She stared at the blaze, and then around at the forest. It was very dark, now. The sky had faded to pitch blackness faster than Ryoka could ever remember seeing, except maybe in a country like Poland, where sunlight might only last for three hours each day.

“The fire is growing. Good. Keep it burning bright, Ryoka. Do not let it go out.”

“You don’t have to tell me twice.”

Ryoka shuddered, feeling herself warm up. But it wasn’t the need for heat that seemed to bother the faerie. She kept looking around the fire, into the dark forest. Ryoka stared around too. And then she felt a prickling sensation down her back.

She didn’t know why, but it felt like they were not alone in the forest. Perhaps it was Ivolethe’s wariness, but suddenly Ryoka thought she was being watched. She stared about surreptitiously, one hand on the knife she’d used to cut the wood. She had potions—some of them were too frozen to use, but Ryoka could warm them at the fire. The girl cursed as she suddenly realized she could have used the ignition potion for the flour bomb that Octavia had given her to light the fire!

But...perhaps it was best she hadn't used it. Ryoka stared about. It was cold, and she could only hear the blowing wind. But she felt it now, the same as Ivolethe.

Something was out there. And it was watching her.

They were three. They stood in her inn, the closed door behind them. Erin hadn't heard them come in. She turned, caught off-guard, but the three didn't seem like they meant to harm her.

"My apologies, Miss Innkeeper. We do not mean to intrude, but the storm outside pushed us in. We come bearing no ill will. May we seek the hospitality of your hearth on this dark day?"

The first who spoke was a man who stood taller than any man that Erin had ever seen. He was not a giant or *stretched*, like a basketball player was, though. He simply stood as if he looked down upon everyone and everything.

He had a beard, and a face that reminded Erin of Abraham Lincoln. Perhaps it was just the way his features looked? His nose? No—there was just something timeless about his appearance, Erin decided. Like Teddy Roosevelt, someone who defined his time, who stood out.

He had a beard. And an air about him that made Erin forget his companions for a second. But then she saw a man standing next to him, tall, taller than the first, actually, but who didn't have his presence. He was slightly hunched, and thin. He looked like a librarian, or a scholar, or what such people were supposed to look like.

He held a book in his hands. It was faded and worn and looked as though it were ancient. But Erin's eyes passed from him to her third guest, because the last man who stood in her inn didn't strike her as a man at all, at first.

He...it was a he, Erin thought, was not beautiful or handsome. That was surprising, because Erin felt he *should* have been. But he simply looked like someone Erin vaguely recognized, as if he had the features of someone Erin had known. But she had never met him before, she was certain.

And he looked like a guy. Now Erin was uncertain of why she'd ever thought he was she. Perhaps it was the way he moved. He was graceful in the way the other two weren't.

There they stood, the three of them. Erin stared at them in confusion, and then smiled.

“Um. Hello. Welcome. I’m sorry. I didn’t hear you come in. Please... welcome.”

The three bowed their heads, almost as one. Erin walked towards them, feeling lightheaded. She hadn’t eaten.

“You look like travelers. Are you lost?”

“Not lost, Miss. Simply weary. I thank you for allowing us to enter your inn.”

The tall, thin man with the book smiled down at Erin. She smiled back, staring into eyes paler than the moon, but deeper than any ocean.

“My door is always open, especially to people who need food and rest. Can I...can I get you something to eat?”

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

The three spoke almost as one. The man who walked like a dancer bowed to Erin, smiling broadly.

“It has been a long time since we ate anything. Whatever you offer, we will gladly partake.”

“Just a second then. I’ll get what I have!”

Erin rushed into the kitchen. She wasn’t sure what she pulled out, but it felt like she was searching for food, frying and cooking at the same time, and then bringing the dishes out to the three men all at once. How much time had passed? A second? Hours?

“A feast!”

The man with the beard declared that as Erin filled the table for them. He and the other two men began to eat, not without manners, but in a way that told Erin they were starved.

“Can I get you anything else?”

She wanted to keep serving them food, famished as they seemed. But to her surprise, the man with the beard bade her sit.

“Come. Eat with us, our generous host. ‘Tis been far too long since we passed the time with anyone else.”

“Are you sure?”

“We insist.”

The other two beckoned Erin over as well. So she sat, and began to eat with them. And until that moment, Erin hadn't realized how hungry she was herself. In moments she was scarfing down the food with the three.

And then...how strange it was. Erin felt like her guests were no more strangers to her than any of her regular customers. She sat and ate and laughed with them as if she'd known them her entire life. They were familiar, in a way Erin couldn't name.

When it was over, again, as if in the blink of an eye, Erin sat with the other three around the fire, warming herself. The three men complimented her on her food as she demurred. Then the one with the book sighed as he stared at the sliver of night through one of Erin's shuttered windows.

"It is dark and cold outside. I fear our companions face the storm alone at this moment."

"Oh no. Are they lost too? Should we go get them?"

Erin started for the door.

"No."

The man with the beard stopped Erin.

"It would not do to venture out in such a storm at the moment. Things lurk in the shadows. They wait. Better to stay indoors."

"But your friends..."

He shook his head, and the other two did likewise, making the same motion at the exact same time.

"They are lost as we are, but do not fear. We will meet again in time. That is a certainty, and they do not fear the storm."

"If you're sure—what are their names? I can put up posters, ask about..."

The three men laughed as if Erin had said something hilarious. The man with the beard shook his head again.

"Do not worry. They will come in time. As for names...it would be pointless to ask. Few remember my name, let alone the others."

"Your name? I'm sorry, you never said. What's your name?"

"Some call me Tamaroth, little innkeeper. But how are you called?"

Erin realized she'd never introduced herself, even after all this time! She blushed; sitting with them had felt so natural she hadn't thought of it.

"I'm Erin Solstice."

They sighed, hearing it. As if her name were special. The three men stood around Erin, and she didn't know when they moved. When the next

person spoke, it was the graceful man.

“Well then. You have fed us and given us the hospitality of your home. For that, we are thankful. And so we have three things to offer you, Erin Solstice. Three gifts.”

“Gifts? For me—I couldn’t. I—”

“We insist. Three gifts, but you may only accept one from us. And in return, on this day, the solstice for which you are named...we would ask only one thing in return.”

“What? A gift for a gift? Well, okay, but what is it? I don’t have much to give...”

She had coin and food, but she didn’t feel these men needed either. But they wanted something of her. She didn’t know what, but she knew she had it. The three drew closer, smiling.

“You have it right here. All we ask is it for one of our gifts. It is a small thing. Will you give it?”

“What is it I have?”

They told her.

The fire was warm. Ryoka stared into it, and then into the night. By her side, Ivolethe looked around darkly.

“I do not trust this storm, Ryoka. It is...strange. Even to me. I did not predict its coming, and I cannot see what lies in the darkness. Do not stray from the fire.”

She didn’t need to tell Ryoka twice. In the wilderness, the blackness around the fire that Ryoka had built was absolute. Just a few feet away from the fire, Ryoka was sure she’d lose her way instantly. She was glad she’d piled up enough wood to last the night; she didn’t want to move anywhere.

Ryoka glanced into the darkness and shuddered. She couldn’t see the trees anymore. That was how black it was. Pitch black wasn’t close to this level of...oblivion. She shuddered and glanced back towards the fire—

And there they were. Three people, sitting around the fire with Ryoka. They had made no sound, and Ryoka had not seen them move. But there they were.

“What the—”

She scrambled backwards. Ivolethe looked and cried out in astonishment. But the three sat, calmly, hands stretched out to the fire. Three.

One was a woman not much older than Ryoka. She looked scarred, liked a warrior. She turned her face to Ryoka, and the girl saw her smile.

The second was an old woman. She sat with gnarled hands outstretched, greedily staring into the flames. When she looked at Ryoka, it was with a gentle expression, like a grandmother staring at a child.

And the third? The third was not—Ryoka tried to stare at it. Her eyes moved away. It was not—

It was not anything Ryoka could describe. It sat. But sat wasn't the right word. It was rigid, in a way bodies and...flesh was not. But it was there, too. It sat at the fire, warming itself or letting itself be warmed.

And it too looked at Ryoka. She felt its gaze upon her.

“Who are you? How the hell did you get here?”

Ryoka's voice shook as she stood, staring at her three guests. They looked at her as Ivolethe clung to Ryoka's clothing. It was the young woman who spoke first.

“We are cold, and came out of the storm to seek shelter. Would you begrudge us the fire, young traveler?”

The old woman was next. She edged closer to the fire, eyes fixed on Ryoka the entire time.

“We ask for your hospitality and grace in the storm. Will you give it to us, oh lost child?”

The third said nothing, but Ryoka knew it asked the same.

“Say no. Turn them away.”

Ivolethe whispered in Ryoka's ear. But the girl hesitated. She stared at the three. They looked so cold. Colder than ice, as if they'd been caught in the storm without protection for...

“I—I suppose so.”

The faerie made a sound, but the three at the fire smiled so broadly that Ryoka relaxed her guard. The old woman beckoned Ryoka back.

“A blessing upon you. Come, sit. Share the fire you have built with us. The darkness is deep, and it would not do to let the fire go out.”

There was truth in that. Ryoka sat back down, away from the other three, and cautiously fed the fire another piece of wood. The three watched as the flames consumed the stick.

“How...did you get here? I didn’t hear anyone arrive.”

“We have been here all along. Perhaps it is you who never looked.”

This came from the young woman. Ryoka glared at her, but she stared back with amusement in her eyes, not the least bit deterred by Ryoka’s look.

“Okay. Then who are you? Where do you come from?”

“That is a long story. We can tell it, but perhaps...young woman, would you offer me your hand? I wish to sit next to you and it is cold.”

The old woman stretched out her hand towards Ryoka. The girl hesitated. She didn’t want to sit next to the old woman, but she looked *cold...*

“Do not do it! Let us be away, Ryoka!”

A voice in her ear. Ryoka hesitated, and then looked at Ivolethe. The old woman frowned at the tiny faerie on Ryoka’s shoulder.

“What is that you have with you, child? It is a thing of ice and dreams. Not good company for the fire.”

“Her? She’s just...Ivolethe. Don’t mind her.”

“She should leave.”

The young woman with the scars said that. And the thing...agreed.

“I will not leave! You leave! Trespassers!”

The faerie *hissed* at them, her eyes narrowed as she clung to Ryoka’s coat. The three stared at Ivolethe and she made another sound, so guttural and wild that Ryoka couldn’t believe it came from Ivolethe.

But then the three looked away from the faerie and back towards Ryoka. It was the young woman with the scars who spoke next.

“Take my hand, then. I see the makings of a warrior on you, traveler. I see bloodshed in your past, and in your future. Take my hand and I will show you what I know of battle and triumph. Of loss and defeat.”

She reached out towards Ryoka. The girl hesitated. She wanted to take the hand, if only because there was something in the young woman’s eyes that called out to her.

Ivolethe pulled at Ryoka's ear. The girl yelped and swatted at Ivolethe, but the faerie only fluttered away. She sighed.

"I'm no warrior. Sorry. And I don't like killing or...battle."

"A shame."

The hand was withdrawn. Now Ryoka's eyes fell on the third thing sitting around her fire. It did not move. It did not reach for Ryoka, but she felt the urge to reach for it.

"Ah, perhaps you want to know who our companion is."

The old woman chuckled, a dry, quiet sound swallowed up by the snow.

"Well, it asks for you to reach out, child. Can you feel it? Can you hear?"

Ryoka...could hear, despite Ivolethe shouting something in her ears. She understood. The thing wanted her to touch it, to...to feel what it felt. To be with it. To know.

Her eyes slid away from what it was. Rigid? It was nothing she could describe. But she knew it was not like the other two. Not...a being. And not a thing. Yet she *wanted* to touch it. That was what frightened Ryoka the most.

She reached out. She couldn't help herself. Part of Ryoka wanted to know what it was, so badly. She wanted to touch it—

Ivolethe *bit* her. Ryoka howled as she clapped a hand to her neck. She felt blood at the tips of her numb fingers and flung the Frost Faerie away.

"Ivolethe!"

The three who sat at her fire stared as the faerie flew back towards Ryoka, blood dribbling down the faerie's chin. Ivolethe wanted to land on Ryoka's shoulder again, but the girl wouldn't let her.

"Now here is a thing that need not be here."

Ivolethe screamed something like a curse at the young woman sitting across the fire. It made Ryoka's ears ring, but the young woman simply frowned at the Frost Faerie.

"Begone, thing of ice and cold."

The flames *flickered* as the wind blew. Ivolethe shouted, but the gust of wind blew her away. Ryoka turned and saw Ivolethe's pale blue light flying backwards, her wings beating helplessly. Ivolethe was blown into the darkness outside of the fire. And she did not return.

"There. Much better."

"Ivolethe!"

Ryoka was on her feet. She started away from the fire, but stopped as she saw the vast darkness lurking beyond. If she went out, Ryoka knew she would never find her way back. It was too dark.

“Do not worry about that thing. Come back, sit with us. The fire is growing low.”

Ryoka turned. It was true. The fire was dying, though it felt like she had just fed it moments ago. The girl stepped back towards the fire, but hesitated.

Why were the three here? How had they...she blinked and frowned. Her head felt cloudy, and she was tired. And cold. She couldn't think straight, but the three seemed oddly comforting to her. She took a step forwards, hesitating as she narrowed her eyes. They were so *familiar*.

“Do I...know you?”

“Of course.”

The young woman looked amused. She shifted, exposing scars on her arms and the side of her face. She smiled at Ryoka as if they were old friends.

“We know each other, even if you do not remember. But sit. Sit, and join us.”

“Yes, join us. Stoke the fire, and sit with us.”

The other two echoed her words. Ryoka hesitated, and drew nearer to the fire. It was growing low. The old woman stretched her hand out to Ryoka, staring her in the eye.

“I offer again. Hold my hand, child. Be free of your worries with me.”

She held her hand out to Ryoka through the flames. It was a hand that promised Ryoka relief. A place to sit, somewhere to rest...Ryoka hesitated.

The young woman was next. Her hand was strong and stretched out to Ryoka, scars shining in the fading firelight.

“Grasp your hand to mine, Ryoka Griffin. Fight, and walk with me through a thousand lands.”

Ryoka stared into the young woman's eyes and saw the same promise reflected there. To struggle, to *fight*—

She nearly took it, but the third thing sitting at her fire made an offer. And it called to Ryoka without words. It told her to come over, to sit with it, to...know. To find what was missing, to find what never was.

It was there, telling Ryoka to *touch* it. To let go. To be...

Ryoka took a step towards the fire, and then another. The three waited for her to make her choice. And Ryoka would take one of the hands. Why not? Only...

Something was running down her neck. Absently, Ryoka reached up and touched something wet and warm.

Blood. Her blood. She stared at her fingers and saw the dark liquid on her fingertips. Why? Oh. Right. Ivolethe had bit her.

And seeing her blood triggered something in Ryoka's head. She frowned as she chased after a thought. Her mind felt foggy, as if she were in a trance, or sleepwalking. But there was something...what was it?

Oh. Yes. Ryoka stared at the three sitting at the fire. She had to ask. It felt so obvious that Ryoka was almost ashamed, but she had to ask. It was important.

"Hey. Why could *you* see Ivolethe?"

They stared at her. The old woman sighed. The young woman sighed. And the third thing made no sound at all.

"Ah, it is too late. Look, child. The flames have gone out."

Ryoka saw the old woman's hand point. She saw a tendril of fire licking at the edge of a stick that was burnt to ash and then—

The fire went out.

The light vanished from the world. There was only the faintest glow, of near-dead embers. Suddenly, the darkness was all around Ryoka, pressing in. Reaching for her. She shuddered and stumbled towards the campfire. She had to ignite it again. She couldn't be in the darkness.

There were...things out here.

But Ryoka halted. Her feet refused to move as, by the faintest glow of the campfire, she saw who really sat there. Who she'd been talking to this entire time.

There were no people sitting with her. They had never been there. As the light went out, their true forms were revealed.

Dead things sat around the fire. They were dead. But it was far worse than a corpse. Because they were dead but still moving.

Two faces and a...*thing* stared at Ryoka around the smoking remains of the light. One reached out to her and Ryoka recoiled. The hand that stretched out was not living, but decayed skin, rotting flesh. Bone.

The things were dead. They were rotting and stank of it. They stared at Ryoka, and she stared at them.

It was dark. The darkness was closing in. The embers were fading, and Ryoka could sense things around her. Things not seen, but terrible. Far worse than the thing that sat next to the fire.

She had to have light. But Ryoka refused to go near the fire. She refused to touch the rotting things. But she needed light.

“Magic.”

The word was a whisper in her dry throat. But—yes, that was right! Magic! Magic could save her. Ryoka raised her hands. She called out.

“[Light]. *[Light]!*”

Nothing happened. Ryoka stared at her hands. She couldn’t feel the magic in her, couldn’t reach into that wellspring inside her soul and draw it out. It was as if there was nothing there.

“There is no magic here. Only the fire.”

The voice that came from the thing that had been the young woman was rasping, dead. As rotten as the body that formed the words. It gestured to the fire.

“Light it, traveler.”

“Yes, light it. Or the darkness and the storm will take us all. You can feel it, can’t you? They are closing in. They are coming.”

Yes, Ryoka could feel it. She could feel things *watching* her. Drawing closer. The fire was fading. When it was out completely, they would come. They feared the light. But they wanted her.

Hands reached for her across the fire. Dead things spoke. One looked at her and it knew her name.

“Choose, Ryoka Griffin. Let the fire die and we shall all face the darkness. Or come and sit with us.”

The second hand reached out. It still beckoned. Still promised. But the thing that held it was dead.

“Choose.”

And the last thing sat, true form revealed. Ryoka stared at it and knew where it had come from. From beyond the edge of the world. From the places not meant to be looked into. It told her to reach out and enter those places.

She wanted to touch it. She feared to touch it. She did not want to go near the rotting things. But the darkness was closing in. She had no choice. Ryoka had to...

Choose.

They stood around Erin, holding their gifts. She stared at them, part of her unsure of what was happening. The other part...knew.

All they wanted was a small thing. So small, and yet so precious. It was all Erin had. All anyone had, really. But this was hers.

“What do you want? I mean...what do you want to trade for it? It’s very special to me.”

They nodded. It was special. The three spoke, almost as one. Telling her what they would give her in exchange for it.

Her soul.

The first was the man with the beard.

“I offer an umbrella made from the sun’s light. To bring day into blackest night.”

He handed Erin an umbrella. She took it, and opened it. Sunlight, pure sunlight, the kind Erin had never truly seen, streamed down from under the umbrella’s canopy. She lifted it over her head, and laughed as the sunlight shone around her. For a second, she was warm and she stood in the daylight. So long as Erin held the umbrella open, it would always be bright around her. The light would burn away her fears, burn away untruths and falsehoods. Then she closed the umbrella and the world was dark.

The second was the man with the book.

“I have here a hangman’s rope. For those who live without any hope.”

He handed Erin a long, thick rope with a noose on the end. Erin tossed the end over one of the beams in the rafters and the others helped her tie it securely. She stood on a table, and put her head in the noose. Then she stepped off the table and hung there.

She was dead. Erin hung in her inn, dead. Minutes passed, then hours. Days. Years. When she took the rope off her neck, Erin smiled. No one had known she was alive. They all thought she was dead. While she hung there, no enemy would find her. It was perfect. She let the noose hang over her head as she turned.

The third, the man who danced as he walked.

“I hold a horn made of ancient bone. A thing to protect both hearth and home.”

He handed Erin a horn of pure white bone. It was cold to the touch, but when she put it to her lips and blew, the call echoed through her inn. It was a call that rose above the loudest horns of the battlefield, which travelled the world. Erin knew that in any part of the world, her friends would hear her call. She lowered the horn as the call echoed.

So. There they were. An umbrella that was as bright as the sun. It could chase away all darkness, reveal all lies. No magic could stand against it, and it warmed the skin and brought light. And the second, a noose. So Erin could kill herself and hide from her enemies. She could live in peace so long as she hung from it. And the third, a horn to call her allies and those she loved from wherever she stood.

Three gifts. Each one priceless. Erin stared at the offerings. She stared at the men.

“And all you want is a soul for it?”

They nodded. The three stared at her, waiting. Erin wavered. She stared at the umbrella, the noose, and then the horn. They were so precious. She wanted each one, each for a different reason. And the price was so simple. So small. She had a soul. It was hers to give. Why not trade it? Why not give it?

Her hand wavered as she reached out—

“Did you hear that?”

The young woman looked up, heart beating wildly as she stared around the darkness. The three sitting at the fire looked up.

“I hear nothing.”

“I see nothing.”

“But I heard it. I know I did.”

Ryoka spun wildly, searching for the origin of the horn call. There was nothing. Just the darkness, closing in. She stared back at the fire.

So dark. It was almost completely dark. If it were regular night, Ryoka wouldn't have ever seen the last glimmer of flame in the coals. But here, there were things darker than black. That she could still see meant there was light.

“Hurry, traveler. If the fire goes out, you are lost. We are lost.”

She knew it was true. Ryoka felt something behind her. She stared at the three. If she drew close they would touch her. But what other choice did she have?

There was something behind her. Not just something. Many things.

“Okay. Okay! I’ll...”

She stumbled towards the fire, away from the darkness. The three smiled as Ryoka drew closer. They reached for her, but before she drew in range of their hands, Ryoka stopped.

“Don’t—don’t touch me.”

“But we want to.”

“Yes, come close. Just a bit closer.”

Ryoka drew back. She knew the things were right behind her now, but she *could not be touched*. She grabbed for a piece of wood. She just needed to put it on the fire, but the hands...

“I’ll start the fire again. But if you touch me I’ll put out the fire and we’ll all be in the dark. Understand?”

She heard something like a sigh. But the hands withdrew. It was the old woman’s voice, rotted and sighing that addressed Ryoka next.

“Very well. We have time. But hurry.”

Ryoka knew she had moments. She flung the wood on the fire and desperately knelt by it, trying to rekindle the flames. She grabbed at the potions at her belt, threw them onto the flames. She thought she felt a touch on her sh—

The flames burst into life, high and fierce. Ryoka fell back as the fire roared into life. The alchemist’s fire burned bright, but was already fading. Ryoka hurried to toss wood on the flames as the three sighed and drew closer to the life-giving flames once more.

At last, the fire was stoked. This time Ryoka built it high, tossing almost all the wood she had onto it. It could not go out.

The three sat so close to the flames that they licked at their forms. Now Ryoka looked again, the old woman and the young warrior looked... normal. Their skin was intact, and when they spoke it was with soft, gentle voices. But Ryoka knew what she had seen.

“So. The fire is kindled. But it will not last through the night.”

“No. You have not enough wood. Not enough fuel.”

It was true. Ryoka only had a stick of wood in her hands. And the fire was already dying. The darkness was sucking it away. The storm was

engulfing the light.

Again, the hands reached for her.

“We can keep them at bay.”

“We can protect you. Touch us.”

Touch them.

Ryoka shuddered. She took a step back and glanced into the darkness.

Things looked back at her.

“She wavers again. And again.”

The old woman sighed. But then she smiled. She looked sideways at the third thing and then spoke to Ryoka.

“My companion has a gift for you.”

“A...gift?”

Ryoka started, looking at the thing that sat next to the old woman and the young one. But yes. It hadn’t moved, but now it held something. It reached out to Ryoka, and she knew it wanted to place it in her hand.

“Go on. Take it. It is a gift, freely offered.”

The two sat back. Something had changed. Ryoka hesitated as she drew near the third.

“What if I don’t want the gift?”

“You must take it. It is ill luck to refuse a gift.”

Neither woman reached for her, despite being near to the fire. Ryoka hesitated, but part of her wanted to know. She held her hand out, palm up, and the thing—

Something landed in Ryoka’s palm. She stumbled back as the other two sat up, reaching for her again. Something was in Ryoka’s hand. Something cold and...what was it?

It was familiar. Ryoka stared down at her palm as she drew nearer to the fire. She couldn’t go too far away or...

The light illuminated two pale, long things in Ryoka’s palm. She thought they were worms, but they were too odd. Too different. What were they? She edged a bit closer to the light and then she realized what they were.

Fingers. Two fingers, curled up in the center of her hand.

She stared down at the fingers in her hand. They were pale with the cold, but familiar. Long and slender, tanned from being out in the sun. And at the place where they ended—

Torn flesh. Bite marks. Ryoka could see bone on the end of one of the fingers. It had been ripped away from its hand. She shuddered, and her hand, her right hand with its two missing fingers throbbed. She curled her hand—

And the fingers *moved*. They curled up. Ryoka jerked. She stared at them, and slowly uncurled her hand. On her palm, the two fingers uncurled slowly.

“A fitting gift.”

The dried voice made Ryoka look up. The old woman was staring at her, smiling wide.

“Are you not pleased? Is it not what you have lost?”

“I—”

The fingers lay in Ryoka’s palm. She hesitated. Ryoka wanted nothing more than to throw them away, but she remembered what the old woman and Ivolethe had said. So she shoved them into a pocket, feeling them move as she did.

“Now, child. It is time to choose.”

They reached out again. And this time Ryoka knew there was no choice. The fire was fading.

Ryoka stared at the hands. She stared at the darkness. Both were horrific. Both were...

“No.”

She said it out loud. The three looked at her. She heard a sigh.

“No? So you choose the storm and the dark. It is not better, traveller. Not better at all.”

The young woman shook her head as she said that. But Ryoka shook her head as well.

“No. I choose the third option. I choose this.”

She had the wooden stick in her hand. Ryoka stuck it into the fire, keeping her distance from the things that reached for her. The end of the stick ignited, and Ryoka pulled a flaming torch out.

The three stared at her, all disappointed. The old woman spoke.

“You will not escape the darkness with that. The flame will go out very soon.”

“Better that than staying here.”

Ryoka stepped back from the fire. She stared at the three things, huddled around the flames.

“You’re welcome to the fire. But I won’t join you. And I won’t get lost in the darkness.”

“So you say. But you had better hurry, child. Your time is running out.”

Already the flame was burning down the stick. Ryoka turned and ran. She ran away from the fire, into the complete darkness around her. She knew things were following her, reaching for her and recoiling from the flame. But she ran and ran, knowing what was behind her was just as bad.

The three sat at the fire, huddling around it as the flames burnt down. And then the fire went out.

Erin reached for the horn. But her hand paused. She turned to the umbrella, and then back to the horn. When she reached out the second time, it was for the umbrella.

The man with the beard smiled as Erin picked it up. He reached for her, but she handed the umbrella to him.

“Here. I’m sorry. But I can’t take it.”

He blinked, surprised. Erin picked up the noose and unwrapped it from the beam. She handed it to the man with the book, and then picked up the horn. She stared at it for a long time and then handed it to the dancing man. All three held their gifts and looked at her.

“Will you not choose one? Do you not wish for any?”

“I want all three.”

Erin said it and meant every word. She wanted all three gifts with a passion she couldn’t describe. She would have given anything for them, even her soul. But—

“But I’m afraid I can’t take any of them. You see, I don’t think I should have them.”

“Why?”

They stared at her. Erin smiled as she tried to explain.

“They’re not for someone like me. You see...I’m just an innkeeper. I’m no warrior. I don’t fight battles. I don’t have enemies. And I have enough light. I’m afraid someone else might find more use for them than me.”

The three men held their gifts, priceless beyond words, as Erin bowed her head.

“Sorry. But I’ll have to refuse.”

The first to speak was the man with the beard. He laughed, and the laughter filled the room. He turned to the others and they laughed too, as one. When he was done, he stood before her, grave.

“So. Three times we have offered and you have refused.”

He pointed at Erin, standing tall and proud.

“Not for pride, she declines.”

The man with the book opened it and wrote in it.

“Not for knowledge she says no.”

And the third man stared at Erin and sighed wistfully.

“Not for others she refuses. So it must be.”

“I’m sorry.”

Erin felt bad, but the man with the beard smiled at her.

“It must be. And you have chosen. Innkeeper, I thank you for your hospitality. One day we may meet again. Until that day, I offer you my thanks.”

“And I.”

The man with the book bowed slightly.

“And I.”

The dancing man gave Erin a bow more graceful than a moonbeam. She smiled at them all.

“Thank you. Come back whenever you want. I’ll be happy to serve you again.”

They laughed again at that, as if she’d told another fine joke. And then the man with the beard turned to the fire. He pointed.

“Keep it lit. The night is not over, innkeeper.”

Erin turned. The fire had grown very low. She piled more wood on it, and it blazed brightly. She was about to thank the man for pointing that out. But he was gone.

She turned and they were gone. The three men had vanished without a trace. But in their place, something glinted at the table where they’d sat. Erin went over to it. She reached down and slowly picked up a coin.

It was palm-sized, and looked a bit like silver. But brighter. Whiter. If it was metal, it was none that Erin knew. She lifted it and felt the weight of it in her palm. It was light as a feather.

What to do with it? Erin stared at the coin, and then walked into the kitchen. She looked around and saw the small jar Lyonette kept separate

from the main stash. In a dream she put the coin the men had left in the small pot of coins. Then Erin went back to the fire.

It was low, now, despite all the fuel she'd added. Erin curled up next to it, staring at the flames. Her encounter with the three men seemed more like a dream, now. She didn't even know if it had happened. Erin stared into the heart of the flames and felt a deep exhaustion fall over her. She closed her eyes. In moments, she was asleep.

It was dark. Ryoka ran through the darkness, heart pounding. She couldn't feel anything, couldn't see. It was too dark.

There were things around her. They reached for her with appendages. Some were hands. Others were...different. They grasped at her, trying to pull her back. But Ryoka ran on, and the light in her hands pushed them back, kept them at bay.

But the light was fading. As Ryoka ran, it slowly burnt away, fading into the blackness. Ryoka ran on, searching for a way out. But there was nothing around her. No sign of escape.

Just the night.

"Is anyone there? Someone! Please!"

Ryoka screamed as she ran. There had to be something. Some sign that there was life—something else but the darkness. But all she heard was her own voice, and the things closing in.

Her breath was tearing at her lungs. Ryoka had run so far, but now the torch was a flickering stub. She slowed, trying to cradle the fire as the wind threatened to blow it out. And still there was nothing.

Nothing...Ryoka closed her eyes. Something was next to her. It reached for her, and she knew it was over. She saw the last flicker of light die.

"Ryoka!"

And then there was light. Ryoka turned in the darkness and ran for it, ran for the voice that cut through the howling oblivion around her. She turned, searching for the source of the voice.

"Ivo! He?"

"Ryoka! Come to my voice!"

Ryoka ran. She ran towards the sound of the voice in the darkness. There was nothing around her. Nothing, and yet the things reached for her,

trying to touch her. To...

Ryoka felt something tugging at her neck. She cried out, but the thing hadn't touched her. It had tangled on her scarf and was trying to pull her back. She fought to get free and the scarf tore loose from its grip. She ran away, towards the voice.

There was light. Faint, in the distance, but as absolute as certainty. In this darkness, even the faintest glimmer was unmistakable. Ryoka ran towards it, shouting and hearing her name called again and again.

"I'm here! Here!"

Again, she heard the call and this time Ryoka threw everything she had into the run. She ran fast, faster than she'd ever run in her life. There was nothing that held her back. If her legs broke, if her body tore and bled—if she fell just a step behind, the things would catch her, and there would be nothing of Ryoka after that.

Now she could see someone running towards her. Ryoka saw a shape, a...woman?

"Ryoka!"

The voice was familiar, but the person was not. Ryoka only caught a glimpse as she ran, but the woman was tall, as tall as Ryoka and lithe. She held something in her hands that shone in the darkness.

A sword. She ran and Ryoka ran with her.

"This way! Do not look back, no matter what! Run."

"Ivolethe?"

"Run, fool!"

The sword flashed as the woman swung it behind Ryoka. And Ryoka ran. She ran, and the darkness followed her. But there was light up ahead. Light and—

And movement. Something ran towards her. Ryoka saw something dash by her. A man? No. Not a man. But someone in armor nonetheless, a... being with a sword that had the same unnatural radiance as his face. It was a he, and he ran past Ryoka.

A warrior. But he was not the only one. Ryoka heard galloping hooves, and cries that made her ears ring. Not one, but many beings ran past her, each one male, or so she thought. They ran towards the darkness and kept it at bay. And she ran and ran—

And burst out into the light. Not the light of day, but rather the light of midnight. There were no stars in the sky and the sun had long set. The

clouds were thick and it was snowing and the moon was obscured.

But it was *light*. Ryoka sank to her knees in the snow, gasping, and then saw the blue radiance flying towards her, and heard her name being called.

“Ryoka! Ryoka Griffin!”

“Ivolethe!”

Ryoka struggled to her feet and ran to the faerie. Ivolethe flew towards Ryoka, and the girl cupped her hands so the faerie could land in them.

“How did you find me?”

“Never mind that. Did they touch you? Did anything touch you?”

Ivolethe was looking Ryoka up and down anxiously. The girl shook her head.

“Nothing. What was—what—”

“Do not speak of it. Do not mention what was there, lest you call it.”

Ivolethe put a finger as cold as frost itself to Ryoka’s lips warningly. The girl closed her mouth. Ivolethe studied Ryoka and shook her head.

“Build a fire. You are near death.”

She was. Ryoka looked around for wood, but nearly fell. She could barely feel her limbs. Ivolethe flew off as Ryoka had to sit. She came back with wood and dumped it on the ground. Then the faerie stared at the wood. The color of her body changed and her body shimmered. For a second her crystal skin and living ice body become molten, and her flesh was burning fire—

“Fire.”

And there was. Ryoka pulled herself towards the flames and felt the icy chill around her body fading. She huddled near the flames for a long time, until her clothing was smouldering and she felt blisters forming from the heat. Only then did she roll away and look at herself.

“I—I felt...”

Ryoka touched at her throat and shuddered. Only once had the things nearly caught her. She pulled away her scarf and Ivolethe hissed.

“Do not touch that!”

Part of the scarf that Mistress Yesel had given Ryoka had...changed. The waving pattern had warped and altered, the fabric’s stitching switching around. Forming the impression of a...hand...

Ryoka shuddered as she stared at the impression in the fabric. She tore the scarf away and hurled it into the fire. She grimly watched it burn, and then remembered the second horror of the night.

The girl reached into her pocket, hoping that she would find nothing. But her heart chilled as she touched something at the bottom of her pocket.

“That was no dream.”

She pulled out two twitching digits. Her fingers. Ivolethe’s eyes went wide and she flew back from the fingers. Ryoka stared at them. She tried to clench her hand and watched the fingers curl up.

“What the hell was that, Ivolethe?”

The faerie had no answer for Ryoka. None she could give. She stared at Ryoka with mouth tightly closed, staring at the fingers. Ryoka stared at them too.

They were her fingers. She could feel them. If she touched them, she felt the sensation, as if her fingers were back again. But they had been given to her by...by...

They were her fingers. No. They had been. But they weren’t anymore. Ryoka’s hand shook as she lifted the fingers, clutched them tightly. She closed her eyes.

And she hurled them into the burning fire.

Ivolethe saw Ryoka react as the fingers hit the burning coals, sending up a cloud of sparks. She heard a scream. The girl cried out and doubled over, clutching at the stumps of her fingers. She straightened slowly, gritting her teeth so hard that Ivolethe could hear the grinding.

“Are ye well, Ryoka Griffin?”

Ryoka tasted blood. She felt...she turned away from the fire.

“It’s...nothing. Let’s go. I want to be away from this place. Now.”

Ivolethe nodded silently. Ryoka took off running and the faerie flew ahead. Ryoka left the second fire to die down as she ran through the snow. Her right hand burned and the pain nearly made her pass out. But she kept running, on and on, away from this place. Back towards Invrisil.

And she didn’t look back. Not once.

“Erin? *Erin!*”

Erin woke up slowly, to someone shaking her.

“Huh? What’s that? Lyonette?”

The girl was shaking Erin, looking worried. As Erin woke up, she realized her inn was full again. There was lots of people standing around her.

Her guests. Her friends. Zel and the Horns of Hammerad and Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers...

And Lyonette. And Mrsha. The Gnoll licked at Erin’s face as the young woman sat up.

“What’s happening, everyone?”

“You tell us. Erin, what happened to the kitchen?”

“Huh?”

It took Erin a few seconds to get up and go to the kitchen. When she did, she could only stare.

The kitchen was empty. Not of people, but of food. All the food in the kitchen was gone. Erin stared at the empty pantry, the ransacked larder, and then at the dishes piled up, and the unwashed pots and pans.

“Did you eat it? All of it?”

Lyonette stared at Erin uncertainly. The girl shook her head.

“No, I—I had a dream, but—”

“You ate everything in your dream?”

Revi stared at Erin incredulously. Ceria shook her head.

“No way. You could have fed us all for days with all the food in there! There’s no way...where did it go?”

Erin had no answers. She only shook her head and stared. After a while, when no answers were forthcoming, the people around her took action.

“I’ll get some food from the city! I mean, I’ll buy some—no, it’s an emergency.”

Lyonette ran out the door and the adventurers who were hungriest went with her to carry things. They left Erin alone, standing in the kitchen.

“Was it just a dream?”

It had felt so real. And yet, Erin felt like the events *had* to be a dream. Surely it couldn’t be—

Her eyes turned towards the jar of coins at the side of the room. Erin went over to it. Lyonette had grabbed a big handful out in a hurry. So it probably wasn’t...

There. At the bottom of the jar, Erin’s fingers found something other than the regular coins. She slowly drew out a coin that shone white and silver, practically glowing in the light from one of the lamps.

“It wasn’t a dream.”

But then, what was it? Erin stared at the coin. She ran her finger over it and peered at it. There was some sort of inscription on the coin. There was a rough border on both sides...faded imagery...she thought there might have been words, too.

But it was all long gone. Only the metal remained. Erin stared down at it, and then slowly put the coin in her pocket.

She walked over to the windows. Someone, probably Lyonette, had thrown them open. Through the glass, Erin stared out into the night.

“Oh. The snow’s stopped.”

The snow had indeed stopped falling. The drifts of snow were piled up very high, but now the sky was clear. And Erin could look up and see the stars and moon. And the second moon, a sliver of a crescent hanging across the sky from the first. Two moons. Sometimes Erin forgot. They hung in the sky, beautiful, lighting up the world.

Behind her, the fire crackled, burning brightly in the fireplace. Erin ignored it as she stared out across the vast world, up into a universe that was not hers.

But it was hers now, wasn’t it? Erin sighed and saw the windows fog up. Her windows. And this was her inn.

Around her, the snow covered the plains, deep, white. Untouched. To the right the city of Liscor sat, dark, the walls staring down at her. But familiar, nonetheless.

Erin reached into her pocket and felt the coin again. Was it just a small thing? No. Today had meant something, she was certain. It was the end of the winter. The winter solstice. The thing she had been named after.

Something had happened. Even if she didn't know what. And looking out into the world, Erin knew more things were happening.

The winter was ending. The shortest day and the longest night of the year was over. Soon the world would warm, and then...

Erin smiled. Oh, that was right. If the longest night of the year was over, didn't that technically make today sort of a new year's? It was close enough, right? Perhaps that was how this world celebrated such things.

It certainly seemed fitting. Erin wiped at the glass and saw a group of people trudging back towards her inn, carrying what looked like enough food to feed an army. Or a bunch of starving adventurers.

It was just a short moment, but Erin was finally alone. She felt loneliness in her heart, and sadness. And grief. But also hope, and the reassurance that came to her as she stared at the people coming towards her inn.

She wasn't completely alone. And so Erin walked towards her door and threw it open. She smiled as the night passed into day and the next day began. Everything started today. She laughed as, in the distance, the sun stopped setting and began to rise.

"It looks like it's going to be an interesting year."

End of Volume 3.

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Author's Note:

This is the end of Book 4 of The Wandering Inn, which coincides with the end of Volume 3. As of this very moment, I am in fact writing 8.33 R of Volume 8...many, many books ahead of where we are here.

The e-books come out slowly, albeit with typos removed. In smaller chunks than the web serial, which correspond to the rather fine audiobooks done by Andrea Parsneau. It is always funny to me that a lot of people find The Wandering Inn via such sources, and realize there's a lot more words yet unread.

I hope that if you are at this point and read this, it is a welcome surprise. Having more to read is always excellent if you truly love it; if it's a chore, then it becomes the nightmare. Still, it's been about five years since I started writing The Wandering Inn and the amount of support and so many readers at this point is humbling.

Book 5 is next, and Volume 4...hopefully some time this year (2021, as of writing). I hope you enjoy it! Thanks for reading as always,

--pirateaba

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Arc 2, Ghostsong — Patreon Preview

(This is the second arc of Gravesong, Book 2. It is a first draft, so bear in mind scenes and plot points are subject to change. Comments are welcome, and remember, this is the second arc of a three-arc story. [The first one is here](#). Check Patreon for passwords.)

Digneral

“They’re weeping as they say farewell to the 4th Princess. Neither Twin has attended as yet.”

The report was followed with an image, a mage-picture. A simple spell, in theory; it was a snapshot of what the caster saw. A perfect image, perfect for [Scouts] or for someone to represent the world and transmit it at great distances.

A simple concept. A difficult spell. In theory, it should be simple to just copy the world as you saw it. In practice, it was considered a Tier 4 spell—beyond the means of most self-taught [Mages] and a challenge even for an experienced one to just pick up.

Conventional wisdom said a Tier 4 spell took about a month for a Level 30 [Mage] to learn. A week if it was their specialty.

A *month*. A Level 30 [Mage]. These things might sound reasonable—until you considered that most people barely made it beyond Level 30 before the end of their life. That also assumed they were motivated, hard-working, and lived at least sixty years.

Achieving that level at a younger age was the mark of talent. So let's say you wanted to generate pictures of...whatever you wanted to see. And you might insist that someone in that position was good at, say, spying. So they should be at least a Level 30 [Infiltrator].

Well, you couldn't ask them to be Level 30 in [Mage] *and* a Level 30 [Infiltrator]. The two classes sometimes synergized, so perhaps a Level 30 [Arcane Rogue]?

Too difficult. Especially if you needed, your kingdom needed, spies in plenty. Far better, then, to demand someone make a scroll or, better, an artifact capable of casting [Transcription of Vision: Scribe Parchment] instead.

...That required either a Level 30 [Spellscribe] and the means to create a lot of scrolls or a Level 40+ [Enchanter] and the means to create *artifacts* capable of such magic.

Ridiculously difficult. Most smaller nations lacked for over a dozen people who had reached Level 40. Level 50 was the territory of champions, and a nation would be lucky to have one expert in their ranks who had risen to that point.

Level 60 was the territory of living legends. The most domineering, dangerous, and influential people in this world had reached that point, like the Titan of Baleros, Niers Astoragon, or certain Named-rank adventurers.

Beyond Level 70? That was the land from which myths sprung. Az'kerash had been said to be that dangerous. The Deaths of the Demon King were on par with that. They could break islands, slaughter armies, and work miracles.

In the modern age, no one dreamed of reaching Level 60 unless they truly were at the center of history, like the King of Destruction. In the past, during great periods of strife and ages of glorious [Heroes], when Dragons and Giants still roamed the world, levels were higher.

Practically, though, Baron Digneral du Ecte understood levels, the difficulties of casting a spell, and indeed, war and the function of nations as all being tied together.

Reducing a nation to the average level of their [Soldiers] was foolish. Assuming higher-levels meant superiority was a dangerous trap many incompetent men and women fell into. However, you *could* correlate the two. Not causate.

It was a concept he'd studied in school, when he was a boy. Correlation and causation, two similar ideas, but one only indicated a possible link. It did not mean that two points were directly influencing each other.

What did that mean? Well, to use an example—you might assume that a nation with a higher-level of its population on average was more successful and, de-facto, a better nation. But that was merely correlation. If you looked into the factors that led to a nation levelling, you might well find that starvation or hardship—or constant war or monster attacks—led to higher levels.

In fact, many successful nations where the populace never had to fear war, or monsters, and could live their lives in peace reported *lower* levels on average. But higher rates of artisans overachieving and rarer classes that could only be born out of peace.

Baron Digneral du Ecte studied nations like other men pursued smaller passions. He practiced the idea of statecraft like a [Fisher] always aiming for a bigger fish, studying currents and bait. Only, Digneral studied monarchs, researched magic, experimented with troop training, and backed projects with gold and his considerable authority to find out what *worked*.

He also employed spies, one of whom had just forwarded him that image on the borders of Afiele.

Afiele, a farming county within the province of Ovela. It exported a lot of Ashwheat grain and was moderately prosperous at best; often poor, but it had been a reliable part of Ovela's weak economy.

Ovela, the most southeastern province of the Kingdom of Shades, bordered Ailendamus to the east and Pheislant to the south. It was often regarded as a rural province filled with farms, as was most of Noelictus, to be fair. However, Ovela had always been important, and the former [Earl], Earl Inameis Ovela, had been well-respected as both a civic leader and general in times of war.

Noelictus was a classic kingdom in Terandria, the continent of humanity. It often conflated the aristocratic right to rule with talent. Another example of terrible correlation. The theory was that the nobility or monarchy, the blood of the Hundred Heroes who had first settled this continent, still ran through the Hundred Families of today.

They would be, then, the best warriors, leaders, and rulers of their nations. In practice? It meant you simply had an established ruling class that could contain talented, inspiring individuals like Inameis Ovela. *Or*—and this was why Digneral scorned the theory—you could get inbred, petty, spoiled leaders with no perspective.

Ovela had been fine. One generation ago, at least. As one of the first provinces to be attacked, it had a standing army on par with the capital's own forces. In theory, Avel, to the west, or Samal, to the north, would also be dangerous foes, but Noelictus had always been friends with the Kingdom of Bows, Avel, and the Kingdom of Keys, the paradise of Samal.

Their eastern neighbors and Pheislant, the Lighthouse Kingdom to the south—those were dangerous enemies. Ovela had fought multiple kingdoms off before, and it had watched in relief as their neighboring kingdoms fought each other—until they were conquered by a growing nation, which had become a superpower before Digneral had even been born.

Ailendamus, the Kingdom of Glass and Glory. The largest nation in Terandria, and one of the mightiest. It had slowed its rapid growth in the two hundred years since its inception, but it was so mighty that many other nations were watching it with unease. In fact, the possibility of a great coalition that would form to take it down was the Kingdom of Glass and Glory's greatest fear.

That was why they were allied with the Taimaguros Dominion, the *second*-largest nation in the continent, in the northwest coast, and why they had not gone to all-out-war for decades. Of course, they would have liked to swallow a smaller nation, like Kaliv, the Kingdom of Griffins to the south of Ailendamus in the mountains, or Pheislant for its access to the sea—but it was difficult.

The Kingdoms of Terandria were old, had long-lasting pacts, and each one had endured because it was dangerous enough to keep the fangs of its neighbors or the other continents from taking its throat. Ailendamus might eat more kingdoms, but those kingdoms would go down fighting.

This was all...background as Baron Digneral reviewed the missive he'd just received via [Message] spell and the mage-picture. He grimaced for several reasons.

Firstly—his [Infiltrators] had only managed to report from the very edges of Afiele. They had tried to enter and report from inside the county, but it was hard.

A poor county like Afiele should have been easy for infiltration, but the opposite held true. A third poor correlation he'd made. *Because* Afiele was so poor, it was hard to infiltrate.

A prosperous capital like Menorome? Easy to slip spies into as travelling [Merchants], visitors, and so on. A county like Afiele? Anyone who wasn't local stood out like a painted canary, and the gloomy land of Noelictus and their odd customs meant it was hard to blend in.

Plus, with the army and [Hunters] roaming about, his [Infiltrators] were in even more danger. He'd sent two into Afiele on a hunch, trying to find out how much damage Feren, the 'rogue' [Necromancer], had done.

Both had vanished. Digneral suspected Duchess Grishen, a capable woman from Ovela's heyday. She had assumed command of Afiele, and both the surviving [Lord] and [Lady] were wards of hers.

Digneral had to consult his notes at this point. Culin and Sasi. Yes. A boy and girl, well-liked by their populace, no outstanding talents, son and daughter of Lord Lantal and Lady Risel Afiele. Now—orphans.

At this point, as he perused his reports, Baron Digneral took another sip from his cup of purified water with a grimace. The water tasted just fine; it was one of his indulgences since he refused to drink wine except when he was on holiday. His crystal decanter and cup were both polished and pristine; if he drank the purified water out of a metal cup, or wood, it would pick up the taste of the other materials.

The water was so expensive and so *clean* that it needed special storage as well as a unique vessel to drink it from. It had numerous positive benefits he thought weren't just exaggerations; it even tasted slightly sweet, and he had observed he felt better if he drank a decanter a day.

It could just be a false correlation, though. Two months of journaling my personal fitness on purified water and two months off over the course of a year may give me actual data on the subject.

Accounting for other factors, of course. It was Digneral's side project.

His *main* project was Afiele...and he wrote a reply back, slowly, still grimacing and hydrating. He was more upset because of the other part, to be honest.

'Acknowledged. Personal details are not required.'

Baron Digneral did not want to see the image of the sobbing children—at a great remove, from the brim of a wicker hat, doubtless the cover the [Infiltrator] was using—or hear they were upset.

Doubtless, the [Infiltrator] thought Digneral would like such details. He was wrong.

The Baron quite liked children. He had none himself, but his brother might well be the one to produce the heirs of House Ecte. Digneral was a bit too

busy, and he was content to wait for an official marriage if the Crown wanted him to solidify bloodlines within his kingdom.

He doubted it, to be honest. House Ecte had proven it was not loyal when it came to affairs of the heart. But that was his family's sin, and Digneral would prove *he* was able to follow orders.

Until then—he abided by liking children and assuming their health was a sign of a prospering nation. Children should be allowed to run about, have fun, study—he had benefitted from Ailendamus' schools and formalized education, a rarity in Terandria, which practiced the antiquated apprenticeship system—and be innocent.

He did not enjoy the tears of children, even his enemies. And yes...they were supposed to be dead, if Feren had done his job. Afiele should have been overrun by undead, the local nobility slain, and created a vast distraction for the rulers of the province.

He did not have to relish the things he ordered done. Nor did Digneral have to consider himself a virtuous man. For his Kingdom of Ailendamus, victory at any cost.

“Digneral! Are you *still* at work? You've barely socialized, and you're due back in House Ecte proper in three days! Brother, let's at least sit with Yietha in the study! The cats are all over us.”

Digneral paused in writing in his [Message] scroll as a loud, jovial voice interrupted his musings. He glanced up—and in strode a man who looked much like him.

Lord Regalius du Ecte was younger than his brother by four years. He was an imposing figure, not least because he dressed to emphasize his frame, and rather than barrel-chested, he looked like he was almost always *on-the-march*. Or standing tall, like he was at his job.

[Lord of Ceremonies]. His red frock-coat swirled behind him, adorned with the symbols of Ailendamus, lance-arrows and the many provinces embellished in thread upon his lapels. His blond hair was combed back and

shiny with an alchemical gel, and he even had a cut jawline—and a *voice* to match.

Here was a man who could conduct a three-hour knighting ceremony in front of an audience of thousands every day of the week, or give a speech as Their Majesties listened at a banquet.

Lord Regalius was a popular figure in the capital of Ailendamus, Wrmeriye. Digneral's understanding was that he was a social figure, much beloved by the Order of the Hydra—one of the three Knight-Orders—well thought of in the Court of Masks, and prone to large gatherings at his home.

The mansion Digneral was sitting in was certainly a social place. No austere balconies or museum-like qualities here. The balcony where Digneral sat was low and open to the garden where visitors were encouraged to pick what they wanted, and the [Gardeners] had standing instructions to let anyone in.

In fact, Digneral had nodded five times to one of the friendly men who seemed used to greeting Regalius by name.

Informal. The sitting room was large, often had cats in it, and Digneral had noticed the soothing green carpet had several stains, despite being well-kept.

You got the stains when little children—not Regalius', but guests'—spilled grape juice. The man even had a collection of toys and a room devoted to entertaining his guests' offspring.

A social man, who looked concerned at his older brother's devotion to work.

When Digneral stood, he had no less erect a posture than Regalius. But his hair was more flaxen, and if he combed it and took care with his appearance—he walked like what he was.

A military man. Briskly, not the more impressive stride, and he wore armor under his coat, even now. The *chink* of the enchanted chainmail made

Regalius frown as he noticed Digneral tucking away the scroll.

“Still communicating with your people, Digneral? I thought we promised you’d rest!”

“Not my officers, Regalius. Some matters can’t wait.”

“Fair, fair. You must think I’m indulgent, what with all our little parties and get-togethers. Rest assured, I knighted over a hundred new members of the Order of Hydra. I hope you weren’t offended by my offering them all a banquet.”

This *was* a rare get-together by the two, and Regalius feasting other people had eaten into their time together.

Digneral didn’t care.

“I know you work diligently at your task, Regalius. Civic duties are as important in their way as mine.”

His younger brother peered at Digneral for a second before smiling and lifting the wineglass he held.

“—If only you could take that to heart yourself, eh?”

He never seemed convinced when Digneral complimented him. Baron Digneral meant it. It was just that...well. He and Regalius had a strained relationship.

There had been a time when they were rough-and-tumble boys, running about, enjoying life, the best of friends. Oh, any brothers fought, but they had well and truly loved each other.

Then had come the marriage. The shame upon House Ecte. *Disgrace*.

Their father had died six years later, shattered dreams, embarrassed to death, or so it had seemed to Digneral. Digneral had enlisted in the army and worked to the bone to make up for the shame.

Regalius...had arguably borne the brunt of the blame. But he'd found his calling as a [Lord of Ceremonies].

It was still Regalius' fault. Both men had acknowledged that fact. Yet there was some irony in Digneral's work of today.

The 4th Princess of Calanfer. The world might be different but for his younger brother's mistakes. In a small way, perhaps, but...

Was it good that Seraphel du Marquin was alive? If she had died in Afiele, Noelictus and Calanfer would have been at odds. However, she was not a dangerous woman, and the 'Cursed Princess' of Calanfer had no actual curses or much use.

Her marriage to Ovela's Earl was going to complicate matters, though. Better if she had died.

Still, and again, Digneral could not quite be sad that she had lived. Especially...his eyes slid sideways to Regalius as he entered the sitting room and looked for a seat.

Instead of a prim and proper room for tea, Regalius had installed no less than six couches in a broad semicircle around the fireplace, and several armchairs. You could, despite the large room, find yourself engaged in quite close conversation with someone.

And if you failed to do that—Digneral stared at a cat sitting on a sofa.

The cat stared back. It was one of those naked cats, without fur, and it looked like a mutated rat to Digneral. He had no idea why his brother loved the things. But the knitted sweater and hat the wretched thing had gave it a look that many people fawned over.

“Colunden, shoo! Digneral, don't mind him.”

The cat hopped off the sofa as Regalius made for the two to sit together. Rather than simply stalk away, though, the cat did a hop *again* in midair... and then landed on a mantle above the fireplace.

It could jump in the air. The *magic* cat curled up and stared at Digneral as if it could sense the [Baron]'s animosity towards it. And another *meow* came from above.

“Ritha’s on the ceiling again. Yietha, do you see?”

Regalius craned his neck up and beamed at another cat who was sticking to the ceiling with its magical paws. A woman calmly knitting another hat for her cats in a rocking chair glanced up.

“I see it, Regalius. Digneral, I hope we’re not boring you.”

“Not at all, Yietha.”

He smiled at Regalius’ wife of many years, Baroness Yietha. A former [Merchant]’s daughter. She had black hair faintly spattered with green—she was shorter than the two brothers, both over six feet in height, and plumper than he remembered last.

She looked—far less like traditional nobility and more like a happy woman with cats roaming around her chair begging for treats, knitting a new cap out of expensive wool for her and Regalius’ pets.

Digneral knew she was actually good at running the staff and mansion that Regalius owned here in the capital. She was charming enough to play host to her husband’s guests and helped with finances thanks to her education.

She was a decent woman and had never actually done anything to Digneral to make him dislike her. But he couldn’t help it.

Digneral disliked Yietha because she was here, not because of anything she had done, and she knew it. Regalius smiled as the two gave each other cool looks.

“I was thinking we should take Digneral somewhere else. I caught him at work—to the Court of Masks?”

“Not there, Regalius. Digneral will just begin talking strategy and trying to get the court on his side. If you want him to relax, you’d better take him

away from the capital entirely. Or he'll be trying to get Duke Rhisveri's ear, or anyone who will listen."

The annoying part was that Yietha knew Digneral better than Regalius did. The older [Baron] shifted in his seat.

He did try to make the most of his time in the capital. Regalius tapped at his lips, giving Digneral a sharp look.

"I noticed that. Maybe another province? House Shoel?"

"He'll only try to get himself invited to House Shoel proper. And they don't suffer visitors. Duke Visophecin."

"Oh, bother. My brother *must* try to talk to anyone and everyone important in Ailendamus—and there's always someone wherever he goes!"

Regalius got up to pour another glass of wine, sighing. Digneral felt like he had to defend himself now.

"I'm simply conscientious that there are many capable people in every walk of life."

"And much do I hate your insight! At least when it comes to relaxing! I believe the exact same thing, but—you're not even having wine. A glass?"

Regalius spun dramatically, offered a cup, and Digneral hesitated. He reluctantly agreed; it was his holiday.

"One glass, then."

"Let's take him to Samal. The Kingdom of Keys. Or Desonis, maybe. Nadel?"

Yietha was brainstorming the issue of getting Digneral to relax. Regalius snapped his fingers.

"Samal could do, but it's difficult to go there and back so quickly. My love, Desonis is *always* raining. Nadel could be good for the dancing, but

Digneral isn't much of a flirter, and you need a partner."

"I'm too busy to flirt."

Digneral muttered as five cats appeared next to him, one literally in a *poof* of smoke. This cat was ash-black and meowed loudly. Regalius prompted his brother.

"Sooty wants petting."

Digneral patted the cat twice on the head and wished it would leave him alone. The cats begged for attention instead, and several tried to knead their claws into his trousers.

"Ah, I can see our pets—shoo, shoo—can't leave you alone. If only to spare Digneral their love—why don't they love *me* like that?"

Regalius rescued his brother, and Yietha sighed.

"Because they can tell you love them. They don't need what they already have, Regalius."

The [Lord] gave his wife such a wounded look that Digneral laughed, despite himself. Then he wished Yietha wasn't so perceptive.

She had named each nation that Ailendamus was *not* planning on invading in the near future. Whether it was instinct or she knew the machinations of the top commanders—and well she might since she was well-placed—none of those nations were next on Ailendamus' list.

Desonis was too wet and too hard to invade. The Sleeping Queen wasn't much of a monarch, but the Earl of Rains, Altestiel, was her war-leader and had strong ties to Nadel, another small nation with a heroic defender. The Lord of the Dance was as skilled at sea as he was on land, and Ailendamus didn't need a difficult fight.

Calanfer and the Dawn Concordat were weaker, for all they were an alliance of three nations. So long as they fought alone—they could be squashed.

Samal was a paradise. One of the few in the entire world. The Kingdom of Keys was nigh-impossible to take by siege, and Ailendamus would *not* try.

Regalius was smart enough to follow his wife's lead as he glanced at Digneral.

"Samal could work...I really don't like Desonis' wetlands unless you want to splash around in the rain and sit in a hot tub *after* drowning on land."

"It has a charm. But to get to Samal in time we'd either have to go north and then west past Deríthal-Vel..."

The land of Dwarves. It was a long road through the mountains, and it would take a week of travel.

"...Or through Noelictus, using the Nighttrain. And that—"

"No."

Baron Digneral interrupted as politely as could be. He smiled at Yietha.

"No. I don't believe I am welcome in Noelictus."

Even if he went through a province other than Ovela...she nodded slowly.

"No, I doubt it. Perhaps Desonis after all, Regalius. Or north. North, perhaps. Kaaz? Taimaguros?"

"I'm sick of Taima and Guros arguing with each other. Nor do I want to die in a Kaazian honor-duel...argh, Digneral would enjoy fighting. We'll consider it for next time, Digneral. *Is there anything you'd like to do while you're here?*"

The [Baron] had really just been humoring his only family. He'd been sipping wine, trying not to worry about the odd rumors from Afiele.

The county really should have been lost. Once Lord Lantal had died, Digneral had assumed it was without defenders. The Thronebearers were

not that dangerous, and Duchess Grishen was far too old to defeat the horde he'd heard was marching on her.

So what had happened? Why could none of his spies get in there? He'd heard rumors...

"Princess Seraphel is in Noelictus. Heading to Menorome, or so I've heard. Just as well we can't visit, Regalius."

It slipped out. He didn't mean to say it, honestly—but he saw Regalius freeze as he lifted his cup to his mouth. Yietha jerked and dropped several stitches and grimaced.

"...Is she? Another marriage? That—poor woman."

Regalius murmured after a long and deep minute of silence. Digneral fidgeted.

"I only meant it as a point of conversation. She's engaged to the Earl of Ovela."

"Aren't they twins?"

Digneral's younger brother was running a gloved hand through his hair, looking pale and unwell suddenly. Yietha was not meeting Digneral's eyes, and the [Baron] regretted bringing it up already. He shouldn't. Their old argument would do no good to bring up again.

But he couldn't stop himself.

"She's marrying Lord Fallien. That was the report I was reading. I need to keep up on a possible alliance between Noelictus and Calanfer."

"One would assume it's on the books if they're soon to be wed."

"It's tentative. More like Ovela and Calanfer strengthening ties, but it may change."

"—Will that complicate your skirmishes with them, Digneral?"

Yietha, at least, didn't flinch from the subject. Digneral nodded to her.

"Possibly. But no troops have marched between the nations. Once I return to House Ecte, I will see if the Twins change tactics. Things have been going well. Afiele was nearly sacked by an undead horde."

She stared at him politely before smiling. It never touched her eyes. Regalius shook his head.

"Noelictus and undead. What a painful nation to live in. Those poor people—I heard of that. Two children, orphaned. I hope they're being taken care of?"

He meant it. He was guileless, earnestly concerned for two children he'd never met. Yietha murmured agreement—but she looked at Digneral, and she knew her brother-in-law's true nature.

More than Regalius.

Digneral met Yietha's eyes a moment before looking away. His brother had done well, marrying Yietha. The best of a bad situation, really. Digneral didn't bear her any grudge. He just thought...

It should be Seraphel du Marquin sitting there. I should be calling upon Regalius, and Thronebearers should be the staff, not silly cats with clothing. Calanfer and Ailendamus, allies. Their position in the Dawn Concordat suspect. Perhaps even the potential to flip sides in a war—or for Regalius' children to take the throne if certain events were to come to pass.

Lord Regalius du Ecte, Digneral's younger brother, said nothing, but the mention of Seraphel haunted him. After all—they had been engaged as children.

Until he broke the marriage by running off with a farmer's daughter who had died in a riding accident.

Shame of House Ecte.

A pointless death. A disgrace that had taken decades for Digneral to even partially undo. House Ecte bordered Noelictus, and Digneral had sworn to deliver his kingdom a nation to make up for the one that Regalius had cost them. House Ecte had fought Ovela in quiet skirmishes for the last six years.

He was so *close* to taking Ovela that he could feel it. Of course, his little war wasn't officially sanctioned by the crown, but—

Digneral stood.

“I do have to report to the palace before I go. Why don't we walk the gardens or something?”

“I suppose that's what we can hope for.”

Regalius had lost some of the pep in his step. But he stood as Digneral adjusted his coat. He felt bad about ruining the moment, but he had a war to continue. He would report to His Majesty, Itorin II, personally.

Then get back to work. Thus went Baron Digneral du Ecte. A man who would arm even his spies with artifacts manufactured by [Enchanters] of Ailendamus. You see—he was a trusted man, despite his brother's failings. He could prevail on Ailendamus' might.

The Kingdom of Glass and Glory was everything Noelictus was not. It was not some gigantic farming kingdom, plagued by undead and subject to market forces. Ailendamus manufactured enough steel to compete with the Dwarves. Its standing armies were armed with state-of-the-art crossbows. It had siege weapons that only the Drakes and Minotaurs knew how to produce.

And magic? It had enough [Enchanters] to produce artifacts no other nation could dream of. Ailendamus was the cutting edge of the future, and Noelictus?

Undead attacks were a fact of life over there. Afiele had been so poor they couldn't even afford to repair their keep. The capital city was beautiful

enough, or so Digneral understood, but it was plagued by corruption.

When it became part of Ailendamus, he would make sure their people never feared undead again, even if he had to scour the land itself of death magic. Those children deserved walls of stone, schools, and freedom from Noelictus' gloomy skies. Color, bright and glorious. Perhaps Digneral could not deliver anything more than conquest—but he would be content with that and let Ailendamus deliver the bounty of wealth that it had given its citizens.

First though—Ovela had to fall. Once that cornerstone broke, Noelictus would lose some of its most ardent defenders.

The Twins were idiots, but capable enough. Other provinces were far less martial. Digneral straightened his coat as Regalius put down his wine cup and Yietha readied herself to head to the palace. Soon—and if he did this, he would be one of the most influential men in Ailendamus, able to speak among the King's personal counsel. He had always known his kingdom had a level of authority above even the Court of Masks.

He was ready.

In this world, few men or women were high-level, especially among noble classes. The King of Destruction, Flos Reimarch, thought to be the world's most powerful [King], was thought to be over Level 50.

No monarch in Terandria could claim to be over Level 50. Even including King Itorin II, Digneral doubted any of them were over Level 40. Maybe one or two at best? Doubtful, really.

In a book written by the famous Krsysl Wordsmith, the most powerful [Lord] in the world had been said to be Lord Tyrion Veltras of Izril, who was at least Level 40. Baron Digneral had laughed when he read the book; he knew for a fact that Lord Hayvon Operland of Rhir, the *fifth* most powerful [Lord], was far higher-level.

Digneral wasn't even in the top fifty. Which showed how much a Drake [Writer] knew.

Digneral left his brother's house, walking swiftly in the cool autumn air. He marched forwards, like a storm, and when his coat shifted, you could see his armor underneath his coat, chainmail glinting and flashing as it caught the light.

Baron Digneral du Ecte. [Baron of the Mirror Lands]. Level 52.

Seraphel

The first time you ever saw it, it was best seen during the day. For you see—then you could have your expectations lowered. The [Princess] was crying a bit when she reached the capital of Noelictus, Menorome.

She was red-nosed, puffy-eyed, and her [Maids], Mariel and Thistel, were doing their best with her face. But it was a messy canvas. Even alchemy didn't help much, although it had a number of tricks.

For instance, the tear-dropper with a splash of bright, cerulean blue liquid kept missing Seraphel's red eyes in the bouncing carriage. At last, Mariel snapped.

"Your Highness! We have to stop those tears, and your eyes need the Soothe Drops. Please, stop moving! We're almost at the gates, and you *must* be presentable."

"Oh, go eat a Creler egg, Mariel. We've left Culin and Sasi! Those poor children—"

"They'll be fine, Your Highness. Truly. They have Duchess Grishen, and if she cannot keep Afiele and her lands in hand, no one can. And they have amazing guardians."

"*No parents*. I should have stayed. What is the *point* of continuing on with this useless marriage? Dalimont, you traitor, say something!"

On the other side, Thistel was working on a rouge for Seraphel's cheeks. The [Princess] had, in fact, gone without extensive makeup for the last few weeks. She had walked about Afiele with little more than a single [Knight]

guarding her and even developed a few calluses from holding bags and hauling things like silverware around.

Not bricks or hammers and nails...there were limits to Seraphel's competencies and the amount of work a [Princess] of the Hundred Families could do. But she had enjoyed feeling useful.

Afiele was rebuilding. Some things might never come back. The town was in ruins from fighting, the keep was haunted by painful memories, and Lord Lantal and Lady Risel were dead. The keep might not be inhabited for a long time, in fact. Duchess Grishen had insisted Culin and Sasi stay in her lands until the town was re-fortified. They had insisted upon being with their people so, as a compromise, the Duchess had housed them with frequent visits to their estates.

All of Seraphel longed to be with them, touring villages, reading Culin a book long into the night so he'd fall asleep, holding Sasi's hand as the girl solemnly met with her people and accepted their condolences.

That little palm, shaking like a butterfly at times and gripping tightly as a vise in others—that was the most emotional Seraphel had ever been. It felt like having siblings, almost.

More than her actual siblings, which was a crying shame to say, but true. She had never been as close with her older sisters, Shardele, Menisi, and Aielef. They had pulled pranks on each other and fought viciously, but soon after Seraphel had turned eight, they had all become distant. The same with her older brother, Lothen.

They were royalty, and there was always the remove of having bodyguards about or their mother telling them not to run about or showcase all their emotions in the open. And the first time you confessed something to your big sister and she ran to tell your mother and you were punished...well, it was one thing for a normal child.

Another for a terrified little girl to be lectured by the [Queen] of Calanfer. Motherhood, that was it. Seraphel didn't know motherly, having had no real examples, but she would have done anything for those two children.

—*But her duty called.* Seraphel had almost been allowed to forget it in the weeks after the siege ended. Then the [Message] had come, telling her that it was time for her to head to Noelictus' capital, Menorome, and present herself to the royal family.

Her father, or, more likely, the [Royal Scribe] taking down the dictation, had been a bit more open in his private correspondence. He had said that the royal family would be 'eminently forgiving of the delay' and that the entire 'stressful affair' she had gone through would be useful politically. The marriage was on, and she had conducted herself well according to Ser Dalimont and in the eyes of Noelictus' people.

Which, of course, was what really mattered. Her father, Reclis du Marquin, was a statesman. He was aware of his daughter's suffering and had apparently done his best to get reinforcements to Afiele despite the undead hordes and remote distance. Now that she was safe, he had written her a private note.

Enjoy Menorome's delights. You are taking a bit of a detour from Ovela, but presenting yourself to the crown will be a good interlude pending your nuptials. I have arranged for a few more [Knights] and a pleasant stay. You will also have a purse of 14,000 gold coins, courtesy of your mother. Do enjoy yourself.

—*Reclis I, His Majesty of Calanfer Eternal, by the Grace of the Eternal Throne...*

Fourteen *thousand* gold coins. Even for a [Princess], that was a handsome sum and probably more than Reclis had spent on the rest of the entire marriage. Seraphel wondered, darkly, what her dowry was. A thrice-married [Princess] was not worth much, but she had heard Noelictus had signed a number of accords in exchange for her hand.

It was her mother who had approved the budget, despite her father's largesse. Queen Ielane knew the country's finances, and that was her way of giving a gift to her daughter. So Seraphel had all this to look forwards to even as she was summoned away from the rural border-county of Afiele

where all the distressing siege, undead, and death had occurred. Her parents doubtless thought she would be ecstatic, all things considered.

Even by enchanted carriage, the ride into the heart of Noelictus and getting from the border to Menorome had taken three days. Seraphel had cried every single one, at first missing Culin and Sasi, then at the thought of the future.

She had been resigned and bitterly sarcastic before her layover in Afiele. Now? Mariel *finally* got a drop of liquid to hit Seraphel in the eye and jabbed her mistress in the eye at the same time, possibly by accident, as the jolting wagon slowed.

But the tears stopped. And Seraphel's puffy eyes returned to normal. She still hiccuped—but despite her grief, no more tears flowed. She was physically incapable of shedding them.

Soothe Drops. A useful tool for a [Princess]. And by then, Thistel had gotten to work.

She had [Steady Hands] for the purposes of applying makeup, and she had been highlighting Seraphel's features. When she presented the mirror, Seraphel saw she'd done a good job.

It wasn't that Seraphel used an exorbitant amount of makeup. In fact, for Noelictus' presentation, the [Maids] had done a very subtle look. It looked like Seraphel's 'normal face'—except that every imperfection had been covered up. Her lips were a bit redder and more lifelike than they should be, her skin contained more hints of warmth and vigor.

"Well, I look ready for my visit."

"Please don't prod at it, Your Highness. And please don't keep crying. The Soothe Drops will wear off in two hours—we've arrived at Menorome! A seat of culture in Noelictus!"

“As much culture as the Kingdom of Shade has.”

Thistel murmured darkly as Mariel tried to cheer Seraphel up. Seraphel resisted the urge to kick the young woman, who wore a respectable, black-and-white, frilled [Maid]’s dress, somber and official, in Noelictus fashion.

She, like Seraphel, had to be here, and it wasn’t her fault that Seraphel was to be wed. But Seraphel let her voice snap as she peered out the window and Mariel pulled the curtains back so Seraphel could get a good look at Noelictus’ capital.

“You’ve never been to Menorome, have you, Thistel? It is a far cry from Afiele, you know. Just like any farming province would be from the Eternal City. Menorome may not be as...bright as the Eternal Throne, but it has its own delights. Or do you not know its nickname?”

The girl bit her lip, embarrassed, as she often did when Seraphel had to lecture her. She was a bright [Maid], good with makeup, and spirited enough for Seraphel not to immediately throw her out of her personal serving staff. Seraphel had never gotten as close with her maidservants as some of her siblings.

Then again—she usually just got annoyed with them, unlike Lyonette, the 6th Princess, who was intolerable. A maid quit every month working under Lyonette. Thistel had a bit of a tongue from being around Seraphel so long. They were nevertheless Mistress and [Maid], so the girl bowed.

“I—didn’t know it had anything special about it, Your Highness. I read up on Ovela since we’re bound to stay there, and it’s quite—rural. Military.”

“Yes. But *Menorome* would be the one perk. Assuming we are allowed to stay here. I was here when I was a girl. I must have been...ten? The entire family was here. Lyonette was just born, and we visited. I remember the dreadfully boring courts, but the music was fine, and we were in Samal and then Avel within the week. Look out the window, Thistel. Ser Dalimont? Slow the coach, you traitor.”

She called out, and the [Knight] leading the group of weary, battered Thronebearers winced and slowed obligingly as they rolled towards the gates. She had been calling him ‘traitor’ ever since he took her away from Afiele, nevermind his loyalty to the crown.

So here was Menorome. By day, it truly wasn’t as impressive as Seraphel’s memories indicated. The road they were travelling was old, battered slabs of stone, some as long as a hundred feet across and forty feet wide. Once, the roads had been paved in a smooth span all across Noelictus. But that had been before earthquakes and years of erosion snapped them and gave them bumps and cracks that could make even the best carriage jolt.

Grey stone, grey landscape, grey skies. As Seraphel had come to know it, Noelictus was a watercolor without the colors. White and black predominated the landscape. The animals, the grass, even the food took on some shade of grey until you forgot there were other colors. Clothing was often black, and Seraphel’s own gown, a deep blue like the night sky, decorated with golden suns around the hem to represent Calanfer, looked like a splash of color in some piece of dreary art.

The [Princess] arrives in the Kingdom of Shade. Yet as Seraphel looked out of her coach, the oncoming city was an aberration in Noelictus’ gloom.

Oh, by day, Menorome was no less grimly utilitarian than the rest of the towns and cities they’d passed. The walls were incredibly thick and tall. Fifty feet tall, and nigh on thirty-two feet wide, ridiculously thick. Like the houses, every building in Noelictus was built to code—to prevent undead from being able to break in.

It meant, even from a distance, the city had a thickset shape, and the few buildings that rose above the walls looked like miniature castles of their own. Impossible to break. The gates were silverish, though, a bright, shimmering metal with a luster greater than even mere silver’s glow. The [Princess] called out idly.

“Ser Traitor. Why are the walls so damned thick? Are they hollow, perchance? I’ve heard Rhir’s walls are fortresses on the inside.”

Ser Dalimont called out, eying Menorome's walls.

"Not Noelictus', by and large, Your Highness. If I recall right, they're built that tall and thick because a Bone Giant might be up to fifty feet tall. The wall is just tall enough to block them—and thick enough to withstand any undead that attempts to assault it. The gates are mithril, you know."

"What, *all of it*?"

Seraphel and her [Maids] were considerably more fascinated by that. That much mithril? The metal was exceedingly rare and hard to manufacture. Then Seraphel shuddered.

"Giants? You mean like that horror that attacked the keep? I thought the days of that kind of monster were lost to myth and legend. Or at least, Az'kerash's era!"

"That was not too long ago, Your Highness, and a zombie, not bone. Lower grade. But yes, the walls are mostly ornamental. Few armies would dream of attacking the capital. In fact, there used to be codes about building higher than the city walls. They must have been abandoned for quite some time that we can see so many buildings from here. Overpopulation would eventually strain a city like this."

Seraphel nodded a few times as Mariel gave Ser Dalimont an approving look.

"He knows so much, Your Highness."

The [Princess] rolled her eyes.

"He's a Thronebearer. They study politics and history. Any more fascinating facts, Ser Dalimont?"

He smiled—she wasn't calling him traitor this time—and turned and bowed from the waist. His leg twitched as he did; it was mostly healed from being broken, but he still clearly felt it now and then.

“A few details, though I have never visited myself. Menorome is far more lively by night, as you are well aware, Your Highness. Oh—and that the walls are apparently laced with special materials within. They are no Walled City’s walls in strength, but I read a quote claiming, ‘no army of [Mages] or ghosts could pass through Menorome’s walls’. I always thought it was an odd claim to fame.”

“Until now.”

Seraphel’s eyes sharpened suddenly, and she exchanged a significant glance with everyone present. Her tears and grief over leaving Afiele abated sharply. *That was right.* She might have left those dear children behind, but she might see them soon.

Great deeds had occurred at Afiele. World-changing, perhaps, and Seraphel wondered how much Noelictus was aware of. Or how much they believed.

Then they were at the gates, waiting in a very short queue to enter. Menorome, as a capital, had countless visitors and was a popular destination—as popular as Noelictus got. But it was efficiently laid out, and there were more entrances to the city than just the gates.

“*Her Highness of Calanfer, Princess Seraphel du Marquin!*”

She still had to be announced at the gates, and the instant the [Soldiers] heard her name, they jolted to attention. Seraphel sighed as she saw the [Captain of the Guard] himself stride out to meet her and confer with Ser Dalimont.

“Oh, wonderful. We’ve arrived before lunch, but I fear it will be dinner before I set foot inside the estates. Mariel, get out there and expedite the process. I will not shake hands, and if they gossip—let one of the Thronebearers explain everything.”

She was right to be concerned. Even with Mariel hinting subtly that Seraphel was exhausted and that a [Knight] could answer any questions—word had to be carried to the palace and a very rudimentary check done of

their identities and carriage. The [Soldiers] were not so foolish as to suggest checking the inside—but they did sweep the exterior.

For undead rodents, among other things. Normally, they'd sweep for hostile magic, hidden spies, and so on. Just another reminder she was in a kingdom where everything dead came back. Seraphel shuddered, then Thistel noticed something.

“Your Highness. They’ve got stones.”

“[Detect Death]. I understand it’s a spell. Menorome is richer than Afiele by far.”

In fact, it wasn’t even comparable to Lord Lantal and his brave—but impoverished—house guards. He’d had less than two dozen retainers.

He should have had a hundred. A *thousand*. Never a braver [Lord] had Seraphel met. Never a better man. She grew angry just thinking what he could have done with twice the numbers he’d had, and she had known Afiele was not rich in coin. But that was a provincial [Lord]’s lot. His Skills had not been the best. She just wished...

The entire entry to the city did not take hours, as Seraphel had predicted. In fact, it was only thirty minutes, a small mercy given her status and the events surrounding her entry. Yet by the time a [Messenger] had raced down from the palace to offer Seraphel personal greetings and lead the way to the estates...

Night had already fallen.

It was so fast that it took even Seraphel, used to the short day cycles of Noelictus, by surprise. She looked over her shoulder when she realized she was squinting to see people and gasped.

“The sun!”

It was setting so fast she was watching it drop below the horizon in real-time. That was bewildering.

“The sun has never set so fast elsewhere! Even in Afiele, it seemed we got more daylight than that.”

The [Captain of the Guard] heard her and bowed. He, like Noelictus’ soldiers, wore pale white armor. Oddly vibrant and noticeable, the steel painted white until it was like bone.

“Ah, Your Highness, it’s the clouds. See how they gather on the horizon? The sun dips into Noelictus’ shade, and the darkness is more absolute. It looks to be a starless night again. A fine three hours of light. Come full winter, it will be two hours of light.”

He saw her expression and smiled.

“It may not be suited to all, but in Menorome, it will be pleasant. Forgive my crude language, Your Highness. Our inspection is done, and we beg the forgiveness of the Eternal Throne for the delay. Now—enter by light and flame into the City of Repose!”

He stood to one side, and Seraphel realized in the back of her mind that the [Soldiers] milling about and pretending to do more checks of the carriage had, in fact, been waiting.

Those bastards kept us waiting to time our entry? The [Soldiers] stood to either side of the carriage and lowered their spears, and the carriage rolled between them and through those mithril gates into the darkness of Noelictus’ capital.

For one moment, it was pitch-black. Seraphel saw the city at night as the sun disappeared, and saw tall streets of looming buildings, people walking about as if they had an owl’s eyes, hoods and cloaks—all of black or white materials—and the same grim impassiveness she had taken for hostility when she first came to Afiele.

The folk of Noelictus, grey and despondent, the nights, terrifying with the scratching of undead, and she saw her [Maids]’ faces, apprehensive that this would be their prison for a while, a dark city filled with night and shadows and...

And then the first flame flared bright, like a match in pitch black darkness. It burned, a royal indigo fire. A tiny spark—in a lantern of glass, hanging above the first street crossing. Seraphel's eyes widened, like a child clinging to her big sister's hands, and stared up.

Memory flickered. And like memory—a hundred little flames sprang up. They rose, brightening, each one a different color. Bright yellow like gold, orange as pure as the fruit, ghostly green, and twisting shadowy blue.

But even within the same color, there were a thousand shades. Magenta, ocre, and blood red. They rose from candles, magical candles that produced the flames. Each one was set in a holster, ancient, worked brass, sometimes an iron pot overflowing with wax.

Ser Dalimont spoke as the two [Maids] gasped and the carriage slowed. Even the Thronebearers, used to the glory of the Eternal Throne, looked up with wonder.

“It is a crime to douse a light that you do not own in Menorome's streets without great cause, Your Highness. They take it very seriously. Some of these candles date back to ages past. I've heard the Lantern Lands in Chandrar were founded by settlers from Noelictus long, long ago. We stand in the heartland of a truly ancient kingdom, even in Terandria. Here is the foundation of many great families and names. The House of El, of the Five Families of Izril, was drawn from this land.”

His golden armor glinted as he pointed a finger across the city. A great palace of black marble rose above the streets, like a citadel of darkness. But the lantern light glowed off the walls and in the windows as well. For such a dark city—it was as if Menorome were trying to banish every shadow. Dalimont's finger moved across the city, pointing out a keep-like building, the gaping mouth of some kind of tunnel and stairway leading down...and more.

“Here lies the first Hunter's Guild, the Underroads, and the Palace of Tombs, to name a few landmarks. The Synphasia Theatre and the many more attractions of Noelictus' nightlife are all available to you here. In Menorome, no one fears undead at night.”

“It’s beautiful.”

That was all Seraphel said. Despite her dour mood, the sight of Menorome lighting up reminded her that she was not entirely lost. This gloomy kingdom was capable of surprising warmth. Just like Afiele—she had been surprised.

As the coach and Thronebearers proceeded into the city, now, Seraphel could see the pedestrians. They had been frozen, like statues, and she realized they were probably waiting for the change from the unlighted streets into the radiance of night.

They turned—and their heads found the gilded carriage, painted like golden dawn. Calanfer, the Eternal Throne, member of the Dawn Concordat alliance to the southeast, was not unknown to Noelictus’ folk. However, it must have seemed far-off. Certainly, the reverse was true.

The sight of a royal carriage like this attracted no murmurs, though, as it might in Calanfer. Noelictus’ people were silent and, like Afiele’s fields, held a grave stillness to them.

Yet unlike Afiele’s [Farmers]—the citizens of Menorome were not as somber. One pointed, smiling, and another frowned in great concern as they noticed a scar left by magic and the claw-marks of Ghouls. A child stumbled forwards, open-mouthed, ash-locks of hair falling over their round face as they stared up at Ser Dalimont and the [Knights]. But a father tugged them—girl or boy, it was hard to tell—back.

Never once did Seraphel hear a voice. She peered out the window and met two pale *white* irises. A cap of snow sat on that ashy hair, and the long, pleated skirt covered pale white socks and a dress that looked like snow. The father was dressed in black, and he took a weathered hat off his head.

He wore an obsidian black jerkin over warm black leggings, both faintly marked. Seraphel blinked. A [*Miner*]? She smelled the distinct scent of soot on him. Were those work-clothes, then? He could have gone into a Merchant’s Guild and been taken for a [Scribe] elsewhere on the continent.

Then she finally heard the first sound as the child pointed.

“Is that a [Princess]?”

It was a whisper. Almost like a shout, but at such a low intensity that it seemed like a rustle.

“Hush. I think it is.”

Then Seraphel’s ears strained, and she picked up sound. And what she had taken for wind became a flurry of voices.

They were—talking! Only, they were so *quiet* that the sounds of jubilation, dismay, the very noises of a busy city were reduced to half-volume. Now, Seraphel heard voices.

“—Calanfer’s [Princess]? The coach looks damaged.”

“Afiele. It surely is. The Hunters made it? What news was heard last?”

“Lord...I cannot remember. One of the border-lords passed. Not Ovela’s Twins. A [Necromancer]. It must be safe if a [Princess] took to the road.”

“Is she visiting? A good time for it, for the Synphasia. Poor, for Her Majesty’s time of ire has never been worse. This [Princess]’ll want to avoid the palace.”

They were talking, but Seraphel’s keen ears, used to picking out court gossip, could barely catch the voices closest to her. They were so *quiet!* The carriage wheels were practically thunder, but she realized even the flagstones they were rolling over in Menorome’s streets drank in sound.

“What a strange folk, Your Highness.”

Every head turned, and Mariel flinched and ducked back. She was practically screaming compared to the ambient noise. Seraphel whispered back.

“Would you be silent? Calanfer’s handmaid indeed!”

Then she raised her voice and spoke, as if unguarded.

“I think it’s fairly enchanting. The city is a piece of art, and the folk dress well, Mariel.”

Her voice carried across the streets, and more than a few smiles popped up as Seraphel’s ‘unguarded’ statement reached the public. The [Princess] affected a bland look, as if she hadn’t noticed.

[A Free Compliment]. Just a little Skill, one of the few that she possessed as a Level 18 [Princess]. It let her say something innocuously nice rather than offensive.

That was Skills for you. She would much rather have had something practical, like a song to raise the dead or...the power to block a Giant’s swing. But she’d take what she had. Besides, goodwill was worth no small sum if you stockpiled it and used it at the right moment.

Ser Dalimont was just as good at adapting to the new city. He pitched his voice low and spoke to the other Thronebearers.

“Her Highness is right. Mind your manners. We are no longer embattled—we are hardly presentable. Prepare gifts and polish your conduct once we settle into her estates. We shall also need to sweep for spies.”

The other [Knights] straightened up. They weren’t that shabby, even to Seraphel, but she had to admit, they hadn’t polished their armor as rigorously as usual. Thronebearers tended to be emissaries of Calanfer, so they had high standards when it came to their manners. She exhaled at the mention of ‘spies’, though.

She had to keep up her public appearance, now. Seraphel almost felt phantom pain in that second—and straightened her back and raised her chin slightly, setting her shoulders so she had perfect posture. Her [Tutors] and mother had drilled poor posture out of her.

However, Menorome was *competing* with her for spectacle. And the city was winning.

Here came the royal carriage of Calanfer, and it was passing figures dressed in black and white in the streets. Like the pieces of a chessboard, walking quietly. The whispers sounded like the rustling wind, but it was not a ghost's city they came to.

Here was the City of Repose, and as the candles burned, casting their colors down, they cut the monochrome colors and made the city look vibrant. Now, in the distance, Seraphel heard more sounds.

Bells ringing. And farther off—the sounds of a violin? It rose and reminded her of the players in the fields of Afiele. Someone was playing, and so quiet was the city that you could hear it from far off.

A master's song. Her ears strained at the notes, and she heard such a beautiful melody that she was actually annoyed when she heard more rumbling of wheels, the *clip-clop* of hooves. Then she turned and saw the delights of the capital.

The City of Repose was a fairly popular place for some to visit. The rest of Noelictus? No. But the safe capital was free from undead, and the people here were afforded all the delights lacking in the more dangerous countryside. As a girl, Seraphel had never understood the peculiarities of the capital.

Having now been to Afiele, she understood the contrast. So she had a deeper appreciation for the entertainment that began to flood down the streets.

Open street stalls unshuttered heavy wood or metal 'curtains', lifted up heavy boards of wood, and revealed colorful interiors. A woman gently placed tiny pieces of cut rock-candy on a tray, and the first child dashed over then respectfully put their hands behind their backs as they waited for the [Shopkeeper] to finish putting their wares out.

Tiny pieces of candy were for sale in one stall, and across the street, a shop selling magical items, wands, amulets, and other cheap trinkets was letting the glow from the crystal ball fill the shop. A sign hung next to one piece of glowing quartz.

‘Crystal Sound-Recording of Synphasia’s Performance, Yoitha Sterngest, Rolairenes the Violinist, upon sale now.’

A recording? Seraphel knew about that kind of magic. Synphasia? Was that the source of the beautiful violin music? She toyed with the idea of buying the crystal, but didn’t want to slow down just yet.

She contented herself with watching. The song-crystal didn’t seem to be selling—but perhaps that was due to the recording itself. It had a *beautiful* violin solo—applause—then a second performer began to play.

Tonk. Ting, tang—Seraphel winced as a *racket* began coming from the crystal. The [Shop Attendant] hurriedly tried to turn off the crystal as the sound of someone hitting what sounded like a bunch of broken gongs began to play through it.

“Is that one of the performances at the Synphasia? I believe I’ll skip that one.”

They were rolling past as the sounds turned back to the violin solo once more. Seraphel turned her head right and saw another new oddity.

“Oh? What’s this? ‘Helpful Servants’? What is this, some kind of [Maid]-service for common folk?”

She barely got a look at the second ‘store’ where young men and women were lined up. They had a simpler version of Seraphel’s handmaidens’ uniforms, and they were standing patiently as a few people queued up.

They seemed familiar with the concept. One was pointing to a price on a sign that said ‘cleaning’. Seraphel blinked, but the concept seemed popular. And the person managing the store had more clients than the rest of the street combined.

The Helpful Servants, nearly forty, just stood there, and Seraphel wondered if they were Golems rather than people. They were so highly-trained...she leaned over as a thought occurred to her.

“Those aren’t [Slaves], are they? Roshal?”

She named the distasteful nation from the continent of Chandrar, and her lips twisted—but one of her [Knights] rode over and hastened to come back and assure her.

“Merely workers-for-hire, Your Highness. I’ve heard of the Helpful Servants. They have been a staple for nearly a century—and caught on in the entire region. Even in Samal. They have not spread as far as Calanfer, but the organization seems to be growing. Excellent service for little pay. Even Her Majesty, Queen Ielane, has been debating hiring a few.”

“Oh, very good.”

Seraphel looked back at the person at the till, who was busily sending out the Helpful Servants. She wondered if their class was [Servant] or [Maid] or...what. They were *very* well-trained. Even Mariel and Thistel couldn’t stand to attention with a perfect smile like that. The Helpful Servants just held place until they were called for their job.

The attendant running things had the same polite look and doll-like movements as the others. Though she seemed more active. Her smile was very wide, a business-person’s too-friendly grin, and Seraphel took this for some kind of scam-service. Yet it seemed aboveboard, and people clearly liked the service, judging from the queue. Then Seraphel was rolling past one oddity among many in a foreign kingdom.

Then the shops she was familiar with quickly changed from the intriguing to the quaintly strange—and then the tenebrous fantasy.

“Ser Knights. Would your guest be interested in resting at a Sleeping Parlor? Sleep or your coins returned.”

A voice called out, quiet, and Seraphel’s head turned. She saw—a mattress? It was lying there, and someone dressed in what looked like pajamas, complete with slippers and a hat, was beckoning to Ser Dalimont.

He reacted as if it were another busker, but Seraphel could not remember... Mariel and Thistel stared at the oddest of shops.

“A Sleeping Parlor? What is it for?”

“Sleep, apparently. Not at this moment, Miss. Out of curiosity, what services do you offer?”

The attendant kept pace with Ser Dalimont, projecting her voice for Seraphel as he inquired.

“Dreamless sleep, restful slumber, dreaming sleep—no nightmares services at the Golden Pillow—but if you would care to sample our bed? You may doze off within seconds of lying down.”

Indeed, the bed on display was being offered to passersby. Most seemed familiar with the concept, so they didn’t lie down, but Seraphel’s lips quirked with pure amazement.

“They offer *sleep* as a commodity, here? The Bedtime Queen of Desonis must love it here.”

She meant it as a joke, but the attendant looked serious.

“Milady, if you aren’t interested in slumber at this moment, why not visit a smoke-spa until you tire? Or—if it takes your fancy, there’s a Moonlight Lounge not a street down—”

She pointed, and Seraphel saw one of the buildings ahead was, indeed, venting smoke into the air at such profusion she would have feared a fire. But it was a *spa*?

She didn’t remember this at all. Then again, spas and slumber were not the sort of thing a young girl wanted. She did remember the Underroads. And she vaguely remembered...

“Is the Moonlight Lounge where you sit under, well, moonlight? I remember that. I have not been here for over a decade, you see.”

“Absolutely, Your Highness. If you would follow me—”

This time, Dalimont stopped the attendant from leading Seraphel’s coach astray. He showed the woman away, assuring her they would be back. It might not have been an empty promise.

“Your Highness! Look, performers. They’re...oh. They’re not [Fools] or [Jesters]. What are they?”

Thistel frowned as she pointed ahead and saw a strange duo performing in the street. Seraphel turned, and this time she *did* know what was going on.

“Oh, firebreathers.”

A man with hair carefully tied back, wearing a mask, paused as he lifted a flaming torch to his lips. He waited until the coach was passing by—then blew.

Fire rose upwards, and Thistel gasped. Seraphel looked up and sighed. A blooming jet of flames rose as the [Firebreather] exhaled whatever was in his mouth. But the licking tendrils of light were not red or orange—but a rosy bloom, pink, and as it rose—erupting upwards, blooming up from the stream of projected flames like a flower opening above a stem rising into the night.

Seraphel clapped her hands with the crowd, and one of her [Knights] flicked a gold coin into a bowl. The [Firestarter] bowed, and another began to juggle torches.

Flame and light. Now, she saw it. Fire, to chase away the darkness that must surely engulf Menorome at all times. It didn’t even feel dark, not on these streets. Why, she felt like it was a second day, and even the black skies above...

Seraphel peered up and blinked. *She thought it was a starless night!* But what she saw instead was a bunch of huge ‘stars’, each shining a different color.

This time, Mariel figured out what was happening first.

“Oh, oh, Your Highness—they must be hanging lanterns! I have seen these! I bought my mother one for a present. There’s hundreds!”

Lights in the sky. They hung from long ropes strung between buildings or floated high in the air on kite strings, and then Seraphel began laughing. It surprised her so much that she didn’t know who was making that sound at first. But she peered out of the carriage, and there she was.

A [Princess], her auburn hair drifting in the faintest of breezes, laughing softly in a city filled by whispers. Firelight glowed across her face, and the colors of a thousand flames made her eyes shine.

She looked so sad. That was what the passersby thought. A quietly sad [Princess], laughing as if she were unfamiliar with how to do so. That was how they first knew and heard of Seraphel du Marquin. And many thought—the [Princess] that many had thought would be a loud ornament from Calanfer might well fit in here. What a shame it was the warring Twins of Ovela who would take up her time.

On, through the city. Seraphel saw people walking out of the Underroads, visitors from Avel, even Samal, the Paradise-Kingdom of Keys, staring around Menorome just like she was. She wanted to stop, but they were heading to the inner city, closer to the palace, where her estates waited.

“A [Princess] of Calanfer? Here? What wedding? What do you mean, a siege? Why has no one told me about this?”

Some people hadn’t heard about Afiele. It had been a subject of worry in Menorome, and certainly, the royal court and nobility had been concerned over the political implications and the threat to their borders—and the rumors of what had occurred with *ghosts*.

But outside Noelictus? The commonfolk had just heard of it as a [Necromancer] raising a horde. Distressing, but not unique.

To foreign nations, it was little more than a footnote. An important one to pay attention to, given that one of Calanfer's [Princesses] was going to enter into a marriage with the Kingdom of Shade. If you were, for instance, the ruler of a nation bordering Noelictus, it would behoove you to know this fact.

However, the man sitting in the slowly rocking carousel of ancient stone had the blankest look on his face. He had a tremendously huge longbow he was leaning on. A Relic-class weapon of a bygone age, which glowed like a ray of the sun.

It was called the Bow of Avel, and the man holding it was known as King Ireimedes, the King of Avel. The King of Bows...and one of his advisors leaned over with a pained look.

"Your Majesty, please. This is a semi-public vehicle. Lower your voice. You were briefed on the matter."

"I sleep through my briefings. One of Reclis' girls is here? Is it the crazy one?"

"Your Majesty! Shut up!"

The King of Avel had a huge congregation, as any monarch might. They were wincing in the private carriage they had been assigned—but the problem was they were in the Nighttrain. And it was a public vehicle that royalty and commonfolk rode in.

It was not impossible for visitors to Noelictus riding in the great, serpentine vehicle of stone and metal and magic to hear Ireimedes' voice. Especially because he was a loud man. The King of Avel kept talking, ignoring his rude advisors.

He was an unconventional [King], but as he liked to say, only a few monarchs had to be conventional, and they were the boring ones. The man was, at this moment, swatting at his [Advisor]'s legs with his bow, using the greatest treasure of his kingdom like a club. He was extraordinarily careless

with it—mostly because he had never found anything that could damage the famous bow.

“Well, the King of Diplomacy’s finally remarried the Princess of Widows. Isn’t that her name? No, wait. The *Cursed* Princess. That’s the one.”

“*Your Majesty, she’s in the city!* And she just survived a particularly nasty siege! If you don’t mind your tongue, you’ll cause another incident with the Kingdom of Shade. Which would force us to cancel your vacation.”

The threat of that made Itreimedes hesitate and lower his voice at last.

“Oh—fine! But I’d better not have to go to the wedding.”

“As it is not a wedding between the crowns—you may be able to avoid it, Your Majesty. It’s to an Earl. Ovela, I believe.”

The King of Avel sighed in relief. Then he got up and paced, swaying a bit, to one of the windows of the Nighttrain. He beamed out of the ancient glass.

“Well, I cannot wait. Menorome again! Then maybe we’ll jaunt to Samal and see about finding some keys.”

He was in fine spirits as he was taking a month-long break from the duties of rulership—whether his kingdom liked it or not. His advisors, who had to make up for Itreimedes’ slack, were less happy about it, but the truth was that keeping the King of Bows entertained was a full-time job.

Where else to do that but Menorome? Or rather, where else but *through* Menorome? Even if the capital wasn’t the sole entertainment for the month, it would be where the King of Bows first stopped.

Since he rode the Nighttrain.

Under the city that Seraphel was riding through were great tunnels of old. They were carved out of the same rock as the Tomb of Afiele and many of the underground structures of Noelictus. Black stone and smooth—it would

have felt like being in the abyss it was so dark underground. If it weren't for the lights, the oppressive darkness would have been suffocating.

Lanterns shone through the vast tunnel, and the thing that snaked to its destination looked like some great, serpentine beast. It had been compared to Wyrms of old, a vast beast of pale scales and windows glowing with light.

The Nighthtrain. One of the last great magical wonders of the world. These tunnels connected Noelictus to no less than three nations.

The Kingdom of Keys, Samal. The Kingdom of Bows, Avel. And the Kingdom of Levicus.

Levicus had waned considerably, despite its claim to fame as one of the nations founded in the days of the Hundred Heroes of Terandria. But the Nighthtrain's underground roads still led there.

It did not connect to other nations any longer. Collapsed tunnels due to war or accidents had reduced a great system of transit down to a single train, which tirelessly travelled the tunnels. Even so, it was faster, safer, and more reliable than aboveground travel.

The Nighthtrain was one of the reasons Menorome was a tourist destination at all, and it had united the local kingdoms throughout periods of strife. Now—the great craft of eight linked cars, each huge enough to hold up to three hundred, floated forwards.

Floated. It never touched the ground. The only sound was the rushing of wind and the *creaking* of ancient metal or stone shifting. King Itreimedes beamed as he saw the lanterns brightening.

“To Menorome, then! Although I hope they have something new. I hate sleeping. And if Queen Nicterise is in one of her moods, I'll be avoiding her. Maybe we should head overland to Ailendamus? They've got some wonderful sights.”

One of the [King]'s advisors whispered in his ear.

“Your Majesty, we’re not friendly with Ailendamus at this moment.”

“Really? *Damn.*”

They only stopped once. The carriage of royalty and her escort of [Knights] had the right of way over most traffic, but Ser Dalimont held up a hand just one time.

“Hold. Someone is blocking the road.”

“One side. *Hunters’ right of way.*”

A voice called out from ahead, louder and more authoritative than any Seraphel had heard. Seraphel, staring over her shoulder at the first pet she had seen—a cat with a bell on its collar, leaping from rooftop to rooftop, pale white paws leaving glowing footprints behind it—turned and saw forty figures striding down the street.

They were on foot, but they didn’t feel the need to keep to either side of the street. And indeed—every wagon and vehicle was hauling towards the side of the road. It took Dalimont only a moment to whisper to their driver. The [Knights] trotted left, and Seraphel blinked.

Was someone dead? But they had said ‘Hunters’. Unlike every other kingdom, Noelictus didn’t have any standing [Knight] Orders. At least—none living.

But they did have the Hunter’s Guild, who fulfilled the same role. They were not adventurers, the common warriors-for-hire who slew monsters and sought out dungeons. Nor were they honorable [Knights].

Seraphel had heard the Hunters of Noelictus derided as grim killers, but when undead or certain threats arose, they were the first you called for. Now came three dozen of their number, striding down the street.

Not a single one had been at Afiele. She knew they roamed, but Seraphel couldn’t help but glare at them. Then the glare turned puzzled—because she

kept staring at something rolling in the middle of this group.

Hunters of Noelictus rarely came out in such numbers. A group of ten was large. But here they were, and she supposed in their own kingdom, it was only fitting there were a lot of them.

But what a sight. Just like all of Menorome, their style was completely unique compared to the more traditional attire of Calanfer. Seraphel would be wearing a classic ballroom dress when she presented herself to the throne, or perhaps something trendier depending on what clothes she had and the purpose of the occasion. But even casually, she had riding dresses, her maids had aprons and a fancy halter top, or perhaps a risqué sheath dress could be worn in private with friends.

Trousers or men's clothing were not something Seraphel could wear even if she wanted to. A transgressive [Lady] or [Princess] of another nation might get away with it, but they were breaking with tradition. That held with most nations...and [Knights] of both genders wore plate armor.

But Hunters? They strode forwards, wearing black trenchcoats, long black leggings, belts festooned with potions, throwing daggers—and heavy crossbows hung on their backs or at their sides next to swords, rapiers, and axes.

Their leader, who had done the shouting, was a grim-faced man with no less than six throwing-axes hanging from his belt. When his coat moved, Seraphel saw long throwing knives in the inseam, hidden in careful holsters. Oh—and he had a wide-brimmed hat, also black, with the insignia of the Hunter's Guild, a crossbow and an odd pointed dagger, on it. More like a piece of pointed wood, really.

The rest of the Hunters wore similar attire. Leather or cloth armor, not metal. But they were armed to the teeth; one had a huge sledgehammer on their back. And they were marching quickly.

What made Seraphel confused about the entire procession of these Hunters was something in the center of their group. It was...a coffin. It was propped upright and being rolled by four of them. It had the sigil of Noelictus on it,

the Kingdom of Shade's scythe, wheat, and hand reaching towards the sky in a stylized crest.

Was this a burial? Why roll the coffin rather than carry it? They did not look like they were in mourning.

Ser Dalimont saluted the Hunters, none of whom returned the gesture. They strode on, barely glancing at Princess Seraphel. The [Princess] had time to observe them and hear whispers.

"Forty. It must be a great outbreak."

"There are more each year. Their Majesties truly do support the Guild. If it weren't for their cards, I would be content...but to see them in their indulgences..."

"Shush. If it's necessary, the Parliament of Land will raise it."

Ah, the politics of another nation. Seraphel tried not to analyze those statements. She watched as the Hunters continued on. Her eyes lingered on the coffin, though. She wondered why—perhaps for travel—there were *chains* on it. Reddish-brown. Rusted?

Adamantium chains *clinked*. They always did, in the box. When the sleeper woke—from their long naps—it seemed as though no time had passed.

Sometimes, all they heard were screams or pleading. Other times, it was just silent and the chains would slither down, and the coffin's lid would fall away.

A few times, every now and then, someone introduced themselves to him. A [King], another leader of the hunt. These meetings were not overly tedious, but they were not the purpose for which the man in the coffin waited.

His eyes opened in the dark. He woke up for a second.

Someone was watching him. He had an unsettling moment of dissonance and worried his heart had stopped beating at last.

Dry lips wet slightly as a tongue licked them. A voice muttered, and the Hunters escorting him halted a second.

“A [*Princess*]. It reminds me of Marquin’s kingdom.”

He tasted something else, even in the coffin that shielded him from the outside world—and the outside world from him. *They were moving, and it felt like Menorome.* They had need of his blades, then. He wondered how bad it was this time. It didn’t matter.

He should go back to sleep. They were getting worried, his comrades. He didn’t know them, but they knew their job. One tapped the side of the coffin, a complex little rhythm.

“Yes. Sleep.”

So he closed his eyes, that [*Ancient Hunter*]. A weapon should not wake until it was used. He drifted off, but before he did, his nose wrinkled. One eye opened again, and that voice spoke in the coffin.

“*I hear a spider scuttling about. Tell the Hunters.*”

It was not the first time he’d said that. The world paused—then he heard a knocking on his coffin.

Affirmative.

So the man called Piortesenzt closed his eyes again and went back to sleep. It was just a little thing. If they woke him for battle with the undead or Crelers or anything else—it didn’t matter.

He would be needed, soon. So he slept.

When he woke, it would be time to hunt.

Sasi

Lady Sasi Afiele cried for three days when Princess Seraphel left. Culin cried for five.

She'd stayed as long as she could, longer than Cara. But she'd had to go and present herself to the throne.

It wasn't fair. Seraphel had been the only person that Sasi could talk to after...after everything.

There was the household guard, and servants, but none of the old retainers who had served along her father like Meltain had survived. The new ones were kind...but did not know her or Culin the same.

They called her *Lady Sasi* now. And they gave her sad looks when they thought she wasn't looking. As if she were dying. The same with Culin.

Old Duchess Grishen they could speak to, but she was busy. Busy replanting as many fields as they could for a winter harvest, rebuilding the town, managing her county and Afiele's. She was also still scary, for all she said she was going to try to be kind.

Seraphel was the one who had been able to hold them and hug them and had all the time for Sasi to cling to her. She hadn't cried...until Seraphel had left.

It was like all the tears she'd had for everything that had happened, her parents, her beloved home, the undead, the [Necromancer]—had been cried out. She'd only found more for Seraphel going.

Such a silly thing. She should have wept for the burnt fields, for the countless dead, for her parents and her town, still smashed open where a horde of undead had burst through, summoned by the horrible [Necromancer]. Instead, she only wept for Seraphel.

Maybe because that was a small sadness and the big one was too big, even for tears.

The wheat was black, as if soot had settled on it. But that was just how Ashwheat looked. The fields outside of Duchess Grishen's castle were wide and plentiful—a final harvest before the cold made it too hard to grow.

Aside from the scorched, black ground, there were plenty of workers in the field, even now. They were harvesting the good crops, replanting fast and hoping for a partial yield.

It was going to be a cold winter. Afiele's siege had exhausted their food supplies, and Ovela still needed its tithe. Grishen had said they would manage, and she would speak to the Twins directly. Even so—the fields were abuzz.

Except for the ones blackened by fire. No one would plant anything there, or for years to come.

The [Necromancer] had died there. It was not that they wanted to honor his resting place. It was more that no one would stomach the idea of planting something that would be eaten on his remains.

The ground, when Sasi walked it, *crunched* with hollowed stalks of grain. The charcoal dust had baked into the very ground, and even for Noelictus—this place seemed dark.

A few scarecrows hung from nearby fields, tall and stuffed with pale straw. They looked...ominous, sometimes. Even to a girl who had lived amongst fields all her life.

Perhaps it was because they reminded her of the undead and she expected the corpse-like figures to jerk, to leap forwards and come at her, mouths open wide.

She had nightmares. Nightmares of them clawing at her, of running through the keep and shouting for Culin. Of...the [Necromancer] reaching for her.

She should have died. That night, in the keep, with her ankle broken, she had hidden Culin in their secret spot and tried to draw the other undead away. They had got her, and she remembered the [Necromancer] staring

down at her with something like guilt in his eyes. Then—he had pointed at her, and the world had gone dark.

The rest of it was a painful dream where she followed him around, magicked by a spell, as he prepared to destroy the rest of her home. She remembered him speaking to her.

“They killed my friends. Burnt them for being [Necromancers]. We harmed no one. You...I am doing to the living what they did to me. Do you understand? I will let you go once I am done. I swear that.”

Feren—that was his name—had said it as if he were trying to explain. Trying to explain why her parents had to die. He would bend down—look her in the eyes—then turn away.

She hated him. She hated him more than she could speak, and if she could have gone back in time and killed him, Sasi would. She wished she had seen him die—but Cara had done that.

Cara, the singer who had brought the dead back to fight the [Necromancer]. Who had sung him a final pyre in this spot.

Sasi kept walking the fields here, when she had time, trying to find the exact spot where he had died. She looked for bones, kicked the soil around—anything.

“Sasi? *Sasi*. Lady Afiele, there you are. Your brother’s in a panic. Make yourself ready, we’re bound to your lands.”

An old, crackling voice called, and Sasi *jumped*. She turned—and an old woman was stomping across the fields in boots reinforced by steel.

Duchess Grishen had once been called a ‘battleaxe of a woman’ by Sasi’s father when he thought Grishen wasn’t listening. Grishen had always been a mean woman in Sasi’s eyes. Judging her parents, scolding—

Now, she was a welcome sight. She carried a mace at her side, and she stomped along, followed by several of her guards. She was...tough.

Unforgiving. But she was not a cruel woman, just hard.

The land needs a woman who will not break. So she had said, and while she did not hug Sasi, she often spoke and let the girl cry or shout and replied with that tone.

Like steel, unbending.

“I told him I was going for a walk.”

Sasi scuffed at the ground, peering down as she did. Culin refused to come here. He was afraid of going anywhere the [Necromancer] had been. He stayed with Ser Dalius, and only the glow of Sasi and Culin’s sworn protectors let him sleep.

That was a change, too. Grishen glanced around as if looking for the ghosts.

“One stays away, the other seeks the bones of that wretch. Neither is healthy. Nor would be staying at your old keep, if it was in any condition for it, but I will move you if only to keep you from obsessing.”

The keep. Sasi’s heart leapt painfully. She would never, never be able to go back into that place where her parents had died, never sleep in the room where...

Grishen’s grey eyes were kind for a moment when they fixed on the girl’s face.

“Enough. I meant a town in my lands, not yours. House Lantal has more than one town. Get ready for travel. We’re bound for Afiele. Then—Ovela.”

She heaved a huge sigh, and Sasi fidgeted.

“Afiele? Why there? Why Ovela?”

In response, the Duchess grimaced.

“Your folk want to know you’re alive, girl. Nevermind they saw you a week ago—can you blame them for worrying like your brother does? Besides, I want to make sure the villages are safe. Not all have walls.”

There might be more undead around. Sasi nodded earnestly, and Grishen went on.

“Then, once we make sure they’ve all had enough food come winter—Ovela wishes you to present yourself. It’s a custom to pay tribute to the [Earl]. Just like it would be in another province. It’s idiotic, now, though. You two are young, and there is no *point*—much less to the Twins. But they want to see Afiele’s ghosts again. That’s the real reason. Pay attention to that—and I doubt they’ll look twice at you. Mark them and understand how Ovela is, Sasi.”

She was speaking like an adult to Sasi, and the girl’s heart leapt, and her head hurt.

“Do you—what do you mean, pay attention to how Ovela is, Duchess?”

The old woman stopped—looked at Sasi, and her annoyed expression, about to snap a response, softened. She exhaled.

“—Dead gods. You don’t know then, about the Twins? No. Your parents wouldn’t talk petty politics, would they?”

“They said a lot. They said the old [Earl] was better, and the Twins ask more and more. I heard some things.”

Sasi was angry without knowing why, and Duchess Grishen nodded.

“Well enough said. Don’t tell *them* that. But they wouldn’t have told you... argh. Another thing to explain. If you go to Menorome, the Landsreight Parliament would be bad enough. *Ghosts aside!* Half the nobility will want to trick you into supporting their petty legislation, and that’s aside from the royal family.”

She spat into the black, burnt fields, and Sasi fidgeted. She loved Menorome and had always begged her parents to go there on holiday.

“Why would that be a problem?”

Grishen pointed a stub of a forefinger at her. A zombie had bit off the tip, once.

“You are a [Lady] of Afiele, Sasi. You have a vote, as do I. A smaller vote since I am a [Duchess], though both our lands have waned so we have only a small say. But a vote is a vote, and they can badger even the crown to get their way. It is politics and not a place for a girl—but you have a *voice* as strong as any other. So when they demand you take part or try to bully you—you will have to argue with your peers decades older.”

Sasi felt afraid at the very idea. However, Grishen wasn’t done.

“As for the crown—King Alloreve has been generous. He has cut our tithe in half for three years already and invited you to the court at your leisure. He will be pleasant. His children? You’ll meet them and forget about them, I trust. As for Queen Nicterise, the woman will either have you loving her or leave you afraid of the palace for years.”

“B-but isn’t Queen Nicterise lovely?”

Sasi protested. She knew of the royal family.

King Nicte Alloreve, the King of Hosts, from distant Kaaz, who had married into the family. A charming man, her mother had said, if sometimes too much.

Queen Cathiel Nicterise, the Queen of Faces, the poor queen, who had her seasons and whom even distant Afiele knew about.

Prince Seratoito, who had married the famous Huntress Agshiga, Commander of the Royal Deathhunt. A clever [Prince]...whom neither her mother nor father had ever liked, Sasi realized as she recalled how they

spoke of him. She hadn't ever noticed they had nothing nice to say, but pretended they did.

And Princess Kadane, who was said to be *spicy*. For some reason.

Lastly, there was the newborn child, who had come into the family far later than anyone had guessed, given how old Queen Nicterise was. Prince Gedal, barely four years old and beloved by his citizens.

Everyone knew the royal family, but Grishen's perspective was of someone who had actually *met* them. She sighed.

"Cathiel. Yes. Hope for a good season."

She was so informal! One did not speak the [King] or [Queen]'s first names. Even when you gossiped about them, you used their last names. But then, Grishen had met them, and she was a [Duchess], closest to the throne by right of birth.

In fact, Duchess Grishen outranked even the Twins, who were earls! But only in status. In practice...she turned to Sasi and gave the girl a serious look.

"The Twins rule Ovela, and Ovela is war, Sasi. We give our grain and goods to Ovela, and they keep us safe. Ailendamus wars across the border with us."

"But it's not *war*..."

If it was war, everyone would say it. Grishen snorted.

"No, it's not a war in writing. But I have heard and seen how fierce the battles are, and the Twins war with the damned Baron of House Ecte like they mean to fight a war hot enough for both nations. It's bloody, pointless —"

"Aren't they defending us?"

“So they claim. But they cross into Ailendamus’ lands too often for *defense*. I will keep you out of their designs no matter what. They are young idiots—even if they inherited their father’s talent for war. None of his wisdom. Fallien and Piral, water and fire, some call them. I just see the same apple, one male, one female. They’ll want your support in the Landsreight. The palace will want your fealty. Your peers, to take advantage of you. And every other idiot to take from Afiele what they can before you’re old enough to hold them to account.”

She was painting a terrible view of the future. A crushing one that made Sasi want to cry and weep. But then a voice spoke, like a burning brand held aloft in the darkness.

“They may *try*. But we will not allow any machinations against the [Lord] and [Lady] of the fields. No longer. We have failed them once—we shall not hesitate a second time if need be.”

Grishen and Sasi turned—and a figure *rose* from the ground. She floated upwards, her sword and shield crossed as she floated, without the need to walk or move, and Grishen’s guards nearly reached for their blades despite having seen her many times now.

Arteis Ladel, Crusader of the Dawn Patrol, a warrior from a time long past, floated up from the field where she had been hidden. She wore armor of old, emblazoned with an ancient sun over the sigil of Noelictus.

[*Paladin*]. Her features, like all the ghosts, were reflected across pale blue, and she was semi-transparent most of the time. When she was angry or passionate, she looked more opaque—and she was the first ancestor of Duchess Grishen.

The woman who had been so mighty in life that she had been named a Duchess, granted the very lands of House Ladel today. She had slain a Goblin Lord in her youth, fought every monster imaginable—even gone to Rhir and fought in hell itself—until she perished.

She—did not look like the woman that Sasi would have expected. For one thing, most of her hair was missing. Half of her head was shaved, and the

other half was long, running down her head. It was an odd look and made her seem even fiercer—she claimed her hair would be black if you could see it, and her eyes had apparently been orange, like embers.

Grishen, white-haired, looked older than her great ancestor as she bowed. But the two still had a similarity that Sasi noticed. A strong jaw, a certain curve to the bridge of her nose—and an expression like either woman could simply eat a Ghoul if need be.

“Ancestor.”

It had taken Grishen a while to find a way to address Arteis. The [Paladin] shifted slightly as she finished rising and then dipped her head. First to Sasi, then to Grishen.

“You need not stand on formalities with me, Duchess Grishen. I am but a warrior and neither your ancestor directly—nor would I claim it now. I am a ghost, a guardian.”

She had never had children, so the Ladel bloodline that Grishen claimed was more distant. For all that, Grishen stared at the woman who had begun her entire legacy.

Not with pure awe or admiration, but with a kind of pained sadness. As if trying to see whether she had matched that woman, for the fact that Arteis was *here*—and so much had been lost for one miracle.

The ghosts had risen once more in response to Afiele’s need. But oh—Sasi closed her eyes a second.

If only they had come earlier, her father and mother would be alive. The miracle at the last minute was a painful one indeed, and it was reflected in Arteis’ eyes.

“Apologies, for my absences betimes, Duchess. I was scouting deep beneath the fields. For bones or other undead. Monsters.”

She had been here. One of the ghosts was *always* with Sasi or Culin. They took their responsibilities seriously, and Grishen bowed her head.

“Did you find any?”

“Moles. Dead. Two hundred feet deep, across all the fields, and I found neither bones nor lurking monsters. Nor those glowing orange eggs you claim are these dreaded ‘Crelers’. I should like to meet them, if only to understand why the world fears them so.”

Sasi shuddered at the mention of the most terrifying monsters, and Grishen nodded.

“If only so you understand their threat, Paladin. Your abilities never fail to amaze me.”

“I as well.”

Arteis tossed her head and smiled archly. Then she frowned.

“Having no body is an inconvenience, in a way. My sword feels too light, my flesh without give. I miss the joys of sensation—and I can well see why Ser Dalius calls it a curse to be trapped as such. But I have been ‘awake’ mere days compared to his long vigil. I shall endure, as shall the rest of us, quite well for at least a decade. So I feel. We have more than enough to do.”

Sasi and Duchess Grishen traded a look, and Sasi felt her cold heart stirring again. In the midst of destruction—came a strange changing of days.

Legends had returned. As ghosts, yes, but they were back. What would happen? What did the future hold?

Grishen looked uncomfortable, though. She turned to Arteis.

“Decades? You do not plan to rest?”

Arteis shook her head briskly and lifted her blade, as if to admire it. Even in death, she held a sword that *glowed* with faint golden light. The edge of the

blade was so fine Sasi couldn't see it, and even if it was a memory—it had surely been a relic of great power.

“The old Tombwarden is gone. My comrades—vanished. There is a great mystery upon us, and until I solve that, I would not rest. However, I have sworn to also guard Sasi and Culin, and for our failures, we shall do so. Afiele has grown poor since I slept. We shall labor to make it resplendent once more. Already, we have slain every undead who rose, and my kin have built the walls first at Landsmecht.”

“So soon.”

Grishen murmured. Sasi's head perked up.

“Landsmecht? Violetta and Idelt's home? Are they okay?”

“I did not go myself, but you may ask my kin.”

Arteis favored Sasi with a brief smile, then returned to reporting.

“The wall stands sixteen feet tall, and we built it two hundred paces around the entire village from the fields. It is made of stones and mortar as we felt wood would be too susceptible.”

“So *large*. And so vast!”

Even Adreissel's walls, her hometown's, were only ten feet tall! Sasi was agog at how much work it must have been! To dig the foundations? Let alone find that many stones? Even Duchess Grishen looked amazed, but Arteis' smile was calm.

“We are ghosts. Nigh on two hundred of us laboring without sleep or rest? Some of us did know the trade of making walls, and the rest can at least learn and haul stones. It took us five weeks to build a wall for one village. We shall do the others faster. Then we will put our hands to other work. Few of us enjoy the act of building, I confess, but we consider it a penance. We shall be of more use, soon.”

Walls for villages that had never had the time or resources to afford them. And the ghosts were also capable of killing any threats, be they monsters or undead, without danger.

“Oh, the Twins will want to do something with them. That’s the true danger. Promise them *nothing*—I only hope the crown will be understanding.”

Arteis had floated off to inspect more spots for danger, and she was flying high overhead. Sasi craned her neck back, not understanding why Grishen sounded so wary.

“Why would they be upset, Duchess? Paladin Arteis is a hero, and besides—now they’re back, they can do so much good.”

“Yes...for Afiele. But an immortal ghost scares powerful people, Sasi. They are beholden to *you*, not the crown. So Arteis and the others swear, and few monarchs would be easy with that, even Nicte himself.”

“King Allorev? But I’m his subject. And so are the ghosts. If anything’s wrong, he can just order us to do something for him.”

Sasi’s head hurt, and she didn’t understand Grishen’s concerns. The woman looked at her, and her eyes crinkled up suddenly, her weathered face filling with laugh-lines as she smiled.

“Ah, girl. Maybe if he hears you say that—all *will* be well. I forget you’re innocent.”

Why was what she said so funny? Sasi didn’t understand. But her heart was full and sad. Full, sad...

As Arteis flew above, she came down a second to shout.

“I should look forwards to meeting these Twins, Duchess! If only to see why they gave Afiele no aid! That young Earl ran off before we had more words and he was speechless when we first met.”

Her face was no longer content, and she had a dark thundercloud of an expression. Grishen glanced up and nodded slowly, no longer smiling.

“I will not gainsay you that, Arteis. Just bear in mind Afiele is their subject.”

“That is only a virtue extended when the right to rule is nobly held. I shall endanger my folk little—but I am wroth. Perhaps they are to blame for... well.”

“Is there any more clue why all the other ghosts are gone?”

Sasi asked hopefully, and Arteis hesitated.

“Ser Dalius, our Tombwarden, has investigated more. The remains of the old Tombwarden *are* there, and not undead or disturbed. I understand nothing. The magic spells? Intact but for the odor. Argh! If only the older ghosts were alive! It seems all older than me are gone!”

She clenched a fist. There should have been thousands, possibly *tens* of thousands of ghosts who should have risen. According to Arteis, anyone over Level 40 would have been able to become a ghost in the Tomb of Afiele.

...But there were only two hundred. And the Tombwarden, the ghost that was supposed to be ever-vigilant, was gone. Ser Dalius, the lost [Knight], had never been put to sleep properly, and he had been alone for...ages.

Something had gone wrong. In lieu of guidance, the ghosts had appointed Dalius as the new Tombwarden and hunted for answers. Grishen nodded.

“Perhaps the palace will know more.”

“Perhaps, but if we have not been summoned in living memory, even for your ‘Creler Wars’, I fear the answers are buried deep. I—will look forward to the summons when they arrive. Frankly, I expected the army and those [Hunters] to insist we accompany them back.”

“Doubtless the crown is processing what it has learned. And gauging a response.”

Grishen replied steadily, and Arteis gave her a sharp look.

“Indeed, I should like to see the exalted throne once more. Light shining through shadow. Hopefully not as wearied by war against the damned Goblin King as last time.”

Light through shadow? Sasi had never heard the Kingdom of Shade described thusly, and seemingly, neither had Grishen. The woman paused.

“First, Ovela. Sasi, I will make ready to go. You have an hour—will you go to the keep?”

“I’ll walk a tiny bit in the fields, Duchess.”

The old woman gave Sasi a meaningful look, but she nodded. Arteis bowed.

“Aye. Lady Sasi, I will leave you to your thoughts. Oh—”

She looked around, frowning, and her sword *twitched* suddenly. The guards stirred, and Grishen turned.

“Something the matter, Arteis?”

“No...no.”

The woman slowly lowered her sword, but Sasi realized—she hadn’t put away her sword and shield. The [Paladin] turned, then lowered her voice.

“I should tell you as to make you aware. Not to alarm you, Lady Sasi, Duchess. But my fellow ghosts and I feel as though we have been observed of late. Perhaps those two spies we captured who drank poison. Or someone else. It seems someone has taken note of our return.”

Watchers? Sasi shivered slightly, and the [Paladin] raised a hand.

“Don’t worry, Lady Sasi. We shall be vigilant. Perhaps it is the eyes of the palace. But I am simply ready to accost whatever watches me. Whatever it is—”

She smiled, and her eyes glinted in that battle-worn face.

“—it fears to meet us. We are foes without life left to lose.”

She stepped back, watchful, and sank beneath the earth. But still—Sasi saw Arteis turning her head. As if searching for something.

Oh, why couldn't life be *simple* after all that had happened?

If only she could have lived in peace for...ten years without anything to do but eat, grow, and think; maybe after ten years, she'd be a tiny bit healed.

That was how Sasi felt. Or perhaps she would never heal. There was a hole in her heart, and it was where her father and mother had been. It was all the people of her home.

It was...her world, in pieces. And no ghosts could fill that gap.

They tried. But they brought more difficult things when Sasi just wanted to sleep. She couldn't even lie abed. One of them, Arteis, would make her get up, dress, and walk rather than sit.

“I don't *need* to finish my meal!”

Sasi shouted at the [Paladin] at dinner. Duchess Grishen often laid out the children's favorite meals. But Sasi had little appetite. Culin ate enough, but she'd pushed her food around and wanted to sleep. Until Arteis had insisted she at least eat.

The [Paladin] was unmoved. A [Knight] remonstrated with her, and he was clean-shaven, kind, Culin's protector, and the other most important ghost. They all deferred to him, even though he was the 'youngest' by far.

He had been awake the longest in undeath and suffered greatly in isolation. He had a single greatsword strapped to his back and different armor than Ladel's. More ornate, with twisting vines running up what had once been silvered mail.

“Perhaps let Sasi go this once, Dame Arteis? She ate enough at lunch.”

Ser Dalius laid a hand on Arteis' shoulder. She was blocking Sasi's way, and *push* as the girl might—the other woman's touch was frigid.

Frigid, but not freezing cold. Ghosts could sap the life out of you, literally freeze water. But Arteis had shown Dalius how to moderate his touch. So she was more like cold air.

Cold air the girl couldn't move even with all her weight. Light as a feather. Immovable as stone.

Arteis Ladel turned her head to Dalius and replied calmly to him.

"You are too kind to her, Dalius. And you, perhaps, forget how much a child needs to eat."

He bit his lip as he was reminded how long it had been since he had been alive. He sometimes forgot, and he would grow fascinated by a bird preening its wings or the way light shone down in the morning. Arteis turned to the girl as her one hope stepped back.

"Cruel it may be, Lady Sasi, but I cannot let you waste away by turns. Yonder meal would not fill a starving [Monk]. You ate better with Princess Seraphel around."

That was because she chatted and told stories of her family and looked distressed if Sasi wasn't hungry. The girl tried to dodge left, and a hand blocked her. The ghosts were endlessly quick thanks to their levels, and Sasi eventually backed up.

"Why do I have to eat? A [Lady] should be thin."

She tried a gambit that elicited a snort from Grishen. The [Duchess] was hardly frail herself, but she had that austere look some women got. Yet even she leaned over her plate of barley soup, fattened by Corusdeer venison.

"If your mother ever told you *that*, she forgot she was no longer a [Lady] of Menorome. A pampered woman from another kingdom may be so thin as to

be unable to lift a sack of grain. But you had better have the strength to outrun a skeleton and swing a hammer, Sasi.”

“Eat. Even if it tastes like ash. I cannot let you fall to despair, Lady Sasi. And I will have you hate me before you are underfed.”

Arteis was immovable. Sasi had to go back and chew down the rest of her plate before the [Paladin] relented. Even afterwards, she followed Sasi around, even checked the privy before Sasi could use it.

“There’s no more monsters, Arteis!”

The [Paladin] walked around Sasi’s bedroom. It was right next to Culin’s. He had wanted to sleep with her, but the two would wake each other at night, and both would get no sleep, thinking the other was something else—an undead—if they spoke, made noise, or went to the bathroom.

Instead, Ser Dalius would sit in Culin’s room, reading a book, glowing faintly, and the boy slept soundly in his pale blue aegis. If he woke, crying out or screaming, Sasi would hear Dalius’ soft voice, speaking to him when she opened his door to check on him. Often, the [Knight] would be whispering an apology.

She liked Dalius. Arteis? Arteis had agreed not to stay in Sasi’s room, but at least one ghost patrolled the hallways at night, and she did things like float through Sasi’s bed and check the toilets, even floating *through* them, gross as it was.

“We captured two spies, Lady Sasi. The [Necromancer] was after your father and mother. I cannot help but think it was more than coincidence that he lay in wait for Princess Seraphel. I suspect many dangers. In time, I will relax, but vigilance is the watchword of the Dawn Patrol.”

Sasi frowned at Arteis as she got into her sheets and pulled them up to her chin.

“Tell me more about your past. Or I shan’t go to sleep.”

Arteis smiled slightly.

“Nothing would give me greater pleasure, Lady Sasi. I was a Crusader of the Dawn Patrol. Level 43 [Paladin] when I died. Lest you think it was low-level...I was over Level 50 when I was dubbed [Paladin].”

Sasi loved stories of the ghosts, and that was the one upside to having Arteis around. The girl was incredulous.

“No one *loses* levels when they get a new class, Arteis.”

The ghost stretched, and her armor had that sunburst sigil over Noelictus’ scythe and crossbow. Although, her heraldry was so old that Sasi had noticed the design had changed.

These days, Noelictus’ sigil was dark, the scythe often accompanied by a stalk of wheat and the crossbow superimposed in the background. In Arteis’ symbol, the two seemed bright, etched in gold under that sunburst.

A different time. One when Noelictus had [Knights] instead of [Hunters]. Arteis wagged a finger at Sasi.

“Ah, but I did lose my levels. Even then, I thought it was strange. I was a [Knight] for the longest time, Sasi. A crusader. You know what that is?”

“That’s a [Knight] who goes on a grand adventure.”

“A crusade. Close enough, but the nuance is that we went with armies to slay a great beast or do battle. I had been fighting for sixteen years. We had slain scores of Lizardfolk in Baleros—I still remember fighting Hydras in their swamps. I grew up fighting Goblins, so the scaly folk were no more numerous or cunning than they were.”

Sasi had never seen Goblins or Lizardfolk, and she shuddered at the mention of Goblins.

“Aren’t Lizardfolk supposed to be friendly? Mother says...said Baleros was a continent of war and filled with [Mercenaries], but Lizardfolk are the nicest of the lot. She said.”

Her throat was filled with a huge lump, and she listened as Arteis replied. Painful as Sasi was feeling—the [Paladin] was a good storyteller. Just not of bedtime stories.

Arteis' eyes flashed, as if they could capture that orange glow, and she touched the hilt of her sword.

“Perhaps they are in this time, but I knew them as screaming, bloodthirsty things who threw themselves at my sisters and brothers. They marched under the eyes of their Naga—great and powerful serpent-folk that the most dangerous Lizardfolk could turn into. Some had eyes that could turn a [Knight] to stone. Others—strong enough to bend steel without Skills or bite through even magic itself.”

“Why did you go to Baleros to fight them?”

Arteis sat on Sasi's bed, cooling the girl's feet. She shrugged.

“The Eyes of Baleros. The damned eyes give Lizardfolk great power, and wherever their vision lands—Lizardfolk invade. Their great leaders, the Nagatine Rulers, made war from their temples and raised armies of thousands of Naga. We went to Baleros to close the Eyes of Baleros. And so we did. The two artifacts were taken from the temple. The Nagatine Ruler slain—and the relics brought away, that the Lizardfolk threat might end. I did not take part in that final affair; I was fighting through the jungles when the final blow was struck. We did not purge the jungles; there was little will or energy left, and the Lizardfolk were in disarray.”

Sasi was glad of it and definitely not getting sleepier.

“What did you do with the eyes? And when did you become a [Paladin]?”

Arteis' smile returned.

“Ah, well, there was some talk of throwing the eyes over the edge of the world. But few would hear of it; they were powerful relics, so we entrusted them to the half-Elven Archmages at the time. They were building great

cities in the heart of Terandria. I was grieved to hear their goodness in my time became the tyranny to rule.”

Did she mean the half-Elven empires of old? That was why it was amazing to listen to her. Arteis came from ages so long gone that they were at odds with modern sensibilities. Sasi snuggled deeper into bed, yawning.

“So about your class...”

“Ah. I was given it in recognition of slaying the Goblin Lord. For never failing in service of my nation. They proclaimed me a [Knight] among [Knights], an inspiration. Thus, from a [Crusader Knight] I became a [Paladin]. I was Level 50. I dropped ten levels.”

“Why?”

“Well...because I was that much more powerful. [Paladin] is more than a [Knight], Sasi. A [Knight] fights well with blade and sword. Some might learn magic, but most, like Ser Dalius, are fearsome warriors. [Paladins] harness something...*more*. I was granted incredible power and enlisted in the Dawn Patrol’s volunteers who went to Rhir to fight an even greater evil. There I died, but for one year, I fought in hell itself.”

Arteis was not old. She had lived...Sasi looked at the woman’s face and thought she might not have even been forty years old when she died.

Thirties, and she had been over Level 50! Then a [Paladin], a class so rare that not even Ser Dalimont had known about it except that it existed. Arteis patted Sasi’s hair gently.

“Rest now. I realize it is not a story for a child—but I lived in dark times. So do you, Sasi. You shall become stronger for it, I promise you.”

It was not a happy thing, but she was not a reassuring ghost. An honest one—Sasi murmured as she closed her eyes.

“Arteis? Did you die sad? In Rhir?”

The hand paused, and she regretted asking a second, but then Arteis whispered.

“I only regret that I was not strong enough to bring all my foes down. Rest assured, Sasi. I died well enough. And I have kept that strength. They had to bring my fellows and I down by numbers, by trickery, that court of devils.”

“You mean Demons.”

Arteis stood.

“No. I mean devils. They were devils, in my time.”

When Sasi was certain that Arteis was gone, she got out of bed and went out the window. Duchess Grishen didn't make the two sleep high up, anyways.

In fairness, it was several hours after that, and Sasi *had* slept. She'd just woken back up, dreaming of darkness and Feren and Cara singing.

Cara's voice was not as reassuring in her dreams. It was pained, and Sasi woke up, sweating and sick, wishing to hear her mother's voice or her father lighting a lamp—and knowing this was reality.

So she crept out the window and knew the ghost who patrolled outside, the [Royal Halberdier], Mustrec, was an old man too polite to check on a sleeping girl. He had served in the army of Noelictus, and he carried a fearsome weapon but was as kind as could be with a huge white beard and a bald head he was embarrassed about, often covered with his ghostly helmet.

The ghosts really were kind guardians, but overbearing. Sasi crept out of the keep that Grishen lived in, slipped over the walls with a rope she'd hidden in a bush, and went back to the fields.

Normally, she would have never gone *outside* of the walls at night. The dead were an ever-present threat, but the ghosts had put down literally

every undead, even undead mice, for miles upon miles.

Sasi walked back through the burnt field, searching.

Searching for Feren's bones.

She was not doing it because she thought he had been right. She was doing it because...

She had to know he was gone. She might grind up the bones if she found them, scatter them in an outhouse. Toss the powder in a river. No...she didn't want anyone to ever come in contact with him again.

Sasi was afraid that the [Necromancer] was not dead. Could he come back? Cara said he'd burnt to death, but she hadn't *seen* it. Sasi...stumbled around in the darkness and produced a little stone that Grishen had given her.

An artifact. Just a simple one, but she cupped it and whispered.

“[Light].”

A pale glow arose, faintly green, illuminating the ground, and Sasi held it high to search about. She scuffed at black soil, inhaled the distant Ashwheat, and still smelled fire here.

Arteis cares for me. Dalius cares a lot for Culin. But Arteis tells me what to do too much. She's not as nice. She's not mean, but I never thought anyone would boss even Grishen around.

That was what she was, actually. An even older Grishen, and even tougher. Sasi...didn't want to grow up being raised by Arteis. She didn't want to grow up at all. She didn't want to rule Afiele.

She just wanted to sleep next to her parents' graves and forget about everything. To be able to cry until all the sadness was gone.

“I want to turn back time. Please? If I level up—can I go back? Can I...stop hurting?”

Her eyes stung with tears as she roamed the field. Then Sasi tripped over something and fell to her knees. She hurt her hands as she landed and lay there.

Then she heard a rustling sound and turned.

The twin moons, green and blue, were almost always covered by clouds at night, as were the multi-colored stars. But sometimes they shone through, illuminating a dark world beneath.

Dark scarecrows looming tall in the fields. Silent stalks of black Ashwheat. Shadows...rustling. Only now did Sasi feel a familiar, child's fear. But she pushed it down. The ghosts—

—Weren't here. Arteis often left to check the rest of Afiele, and Mustrec was marching around the keep, patrolling it. Dalius was in Culin's room.

But that was okay. Sasi picked herself up slowly, hair beginning to stand on end. She tried to see what she'd tripped on and raised her stone. Then she saw, amongst the black ash, a long line of...cracked yellow bone moving in the light, and her heart fluttered.

His bones.

She'd found them at last. Sasi reached for it—only to realize something was wrong. The bone was still rolling after she'd tripped over it. Which was...normal...until she realized it rolled and rolled without slowing.

Then—Sasi heard a rustling, and the ash around her *moved*. She backed up as a long swarm of ash slowly joined together. It swirled around the bone, and more floated up. Sasi's fingers holding the lightstone suddenly grew sweaty.

“No...”

Her nightmare. The lands of Ladel were perfectly safe—each undead put down, each one put to rest.

Except for one. Except if one skeleton arose—and it was not even all bone. Most of it was ash. But from a [Necromancer]’s corpse—

A skeleton made of ash stirred. It turned its head, and two pale, blue flames lit within the skull. It turned to her, and she made a sound.

“You.”

She almost felt relief, even as she stumbled backwards, trying to turn and run. But the skeleton of Feren was on her so fast, grabbing for her neck, mouth open wide.

You’ll kill me after all. Sasi tried to scream for help, and a hand made out of soot clutched at her throat, choking her. She felt herself being lifted up.

Scarecrows watched as a skeleton squeezed, and the [Necromancer]’s vengeance fell upon Sasi, even in death. There was no Feren left, just his death magic. Sasi was choking, and she knew they would find her in the fields. Her brother would have to put her to rest—and she wished she wouldn’t hurt him.

She hadn’t planned on this. If only a ghost saw her. But there were only the scarecrows. The nearest one was hanging from the wooden post, nearly seven feet tall. But perhaps it was because it had a huge, pointed hat...

A hat?

Scarecrows didn’t have hats like that. Then—Sasi felt a wind blow through the fields of House Ladel. Even as she was choking—the air gusted suddenly, and the skeleton’s death-grip on her throat—slackened.

It let go, and she fell to the ground, choking. She scrambled back, about to scream—and saw the skeleton back up. It turned—and both she and it seemed to forget they were living and undead for a moment.

A wind blew through the fields. It sent the Ashwheat swaying, and the air made a sound like blowing pipes, a thrum of sound that Sasi felt in her bones.

Her eyes fixed on the scarecrow, hanging there. It was just—a scarecrow. Body of pale straw, stuffed and given a crude face. She couldn't see it in the darkness, though. As a ray of moonlight slid down, she realized the scarecrow *did* have a pointed hat.

A huge, black one that easily covered all of it. The hat was black—but not purely so. It had the faintest *blue* tinge to it. Blue-black midnight. Perhaps, if you were going to call it a specific color, the blue of the depths of the sea that Dalius claimed had no light. A black of the world just past midnight, an absolute dark.

Who had put a hat like that on the scarecrow? No...why did the scarecrow seem to be turning its 'head' towards her? It hung there, more like a person than an inanimate object.

The wind picked up, and the strange melody grew louder. An unearthly groan...and Sasi felt goosebumps rise from her skin.

The ray of moonlight vanished. The scarecrow was once again thrown into darkness. The field of tall wheat, yet unharvested, rustled.

Then...a figure stood up from amidst the wheat, and Sasi's heart *stopped* in her chest. The figure was tall, huge. A woman, the tallest woman that Sasi had ever seen in her life...standing up as if she had been crouched in the wheat.

But she had not been there a second ago. She *rose* to her full height, and when her closed eyes opened—an orange glow shone from them.

Orange...with black rings in the center. Instead of pupils, her eyes were rings upon rings, black and narrowing, the rest of her gaze orange, lit from within by a magical glow.

Her eyes terrified Sasi, and the woman looked around slowly. Carefully. Then she reached out and took the hat from the scarecrow's head. She and the scarecrow were practically a height. She put the hat on her head, adjusted it, and turned.

Only then did the skeleton and girl wake from the trance they had been in. How quickly the strange woman had appeared, Sasi couldn't have said. She stood there, in the field, her robes the same color as that pointed hat.

Nigh on black, subtly blue. Sasi had no idea who she was. How she had come here. But she did know this:

The woman appeared in the quiet lands of House Ladel, and the wind heralded her with a song. The Ashwheat seemed to *bend* away from her as she stepped forwards, as if afraid to touch her. And the skeleton?

The skeleton looked at Sasi—and then the strange woman—and then charged at the woman without a word, fist raised. It leapt at her, trying to bite—and she seized it by the head.

“A dead [Necromancer]. Tiny thing. Made of ash. Where lies your soul? Pitiful obstruction, I have come hither late, too late to pay respect nor avenge. You and I fit not this skein. Begone.”

She spoke so *strangely*. Her voice was calm, deep and straightforward, and yet it also had the faintest *echo*. She spoke as if she were a thousand paces away and simultaneously in your ear.

The skeleton struggled once—and she crushed it with her bare hands. Its skull of ash collapsed. It turned to dust—and the woman frowned as it fell.

“Thing. You play dead little well. Even had you a soul.”

The pile of ashes lay at her feet. But she pointed, and the ashes rose, stirring, and Sasi realized the undead had been pretending to be dead! It probably could reform again and again, like the dangerous Greater Undead. It tried to reform as it realized the woman knew it was still there.

But she simply let the ash and burnt bones spiral up—then clapped her hands once. The ash *vanished*, and the bones *cracked*—then disappeared.

Completely. They faded out of the world like a dream, and Sasi felt they would never recover. The clap made the fields and wind go still—then all

was silence once more.

Only then did the woman turn to Sasi and remove the hat from her head. She bowed, once, revealing black hair, and her glowing eyes focused on Sasi.

“Lady of the Fields. Small favors I accord thee, for the price of intrusion into your domain. I come according to pact with the crown of your land. I come in peace and inquiry. I come in sorrow’s domain, my hat in hand. Will you allow me a moment of your time?”

“*Me?*”

The woman stared at Sasi, then past her, almost as confused as the girl. She slowly put her hat back on her head.

“You are the lady of this land, are you not? Ah, beg pardon. The lady of the lands next to this. The heir to this, though the current lady yet lives. Lady moreover still in truth and heart of the land’s need. Anyone can claim temporary ownership of the land, but you were entrusted with it by oldest powers. From river to river. The tomb. This world points you out to me.”

Heir to...? Sasi gulped, and her voice wobbled.

“I’m not heir to anything but Afiele. Are you looking for my father, please? My mother?”

“No. The lady of this land is ye. The old lord lies dead. So I have heard. The land weeps. I have come to pay my respects. The little pest was but a token of my goodwill to thee.”

She knew about Sasi’s parents? Who was this...

The woman seemed as puzzled by Sasi as the girl was by her. She peered at Sasi and then snapped her fingers.

“Ah. Art thou...a child? Lady, if I offend you, I offer you my hat as an apology on which to hang your grievances. But I have some knowing in the

manner of things, and you appear to be small as my daughter once was. Children often need explaining twice or moreover, it seems.”

“Am I a...I’m a girl, yes. Who—who *are* you?”

The woman gave Sasi a satisfied smile.

“Aha. I see thou art too young to know of me. It matters little. I, if you seek a name, have often been called Belavierr. A [Witch], a purveyor of services. I am a guest upon these lands. And I have questions to ask you. An offer to make thee...or is it ‘you’? Yes. ‘I have an offer to make you.’ As my daughter oft rewords my language to more plainly spoken be.”

Sasi’s bewildered mind was finally catching up, and she was conscious of her bruised throat—and the sheer oddity and *danger* of this woman.

Belavierr. She said her name as if it meant something, but Sasi didn’t know it. As for [Witch]...Sasi had heard [Witches] could curse you, and they were strange magic-users often banned in most nations.

But this one seemed powerful. She had appeared out of nowhere and killed a dangerous skeleton by clapping her hands.

“Are you a powerful [Witch], Miss Belavierr? Why are you in House Ladel? And you should present yourself to Duchess Grishen, please. She rules these lands. Not me. How...why...how did you find me and kill the skeleton?”

The [Witch] smiled as Sasi replied. Or perhaps her mouth moved up at both corners.

“Children’s questions indeed. Out of courtesy, I shall answer. Three for three.”

She lifted three fingers, and Sasi felt a chill roll down her spine, as if that gesture meant something. The [Witch] adjusted her hat and stepped forwards.

She was so *tall* she loomed over the little [Lady]. Her voice was still—blankly level.

“Some have called me the most powerful [Witch] ever to live. I do not care to compare, but it has been said I stand amongst their number. I am the only one not yet dead, and that is a victory of its own. Death has not claimed me, so if you wish to call me the most powerful witch of this world, that is fair to say.”

...*The most powerful [Witch]*? Sasi opened her mouth, but Belavierr spoke on.

“As for why I came to House Ladel, I had questions. I sensed the [Lord] of the land die, and my business has ever been wrought in times like these. But my work has been—taxing even in success. The land is odd. And I came to a strange, nostalgic presence awakening here.”

She turned her head, and Sasi realized it was towards Grishen’s keep. Belavierr twitched her fingers, then looked down at Sasi. As if...puzzled.

“I am reminded of how things should be. But the pact was struck without the dead to witness. If they are returning—my business may need forfend continuation. Rather that than *offend*. But to answer your last question, my craft, my magic, leads me directly to the heart of things. I am a Stitch-Witch, you see, and I pulled on the right thread. It led me to the one who rules this land. Simple as following a line.”

“...And the skeleton?”

Belavierr lifted a hand airily.

“I cut its existence to shreds. It was soulless, the remnants of a dead man’s magic. Dangerous if it had a hundred years in this place. But dangerous not at all. A wretch’s poor failing. Any [Necromancer] of true mastery would have come back partly or all together with mind intact. This was just mindless magic. Empty and hollow.”

Come back all together? Sasi was shivering nonstop now. Everything in her screamed to *get away* from this woman, but she couldn't move her feet. The shadow that Belavierr cast was long under the moonlight, and it seemed to wrap around the girl.

"There, now. I have answered your questions three. My turn. What shall they be?"

Belavierr tapped her lips three times, then smiled.

"Question one, Lady Sasi. Have you seen my daughter? Do you know where the one many call 'Witch Wiskeria' might be? I fear she's left the continent, but I ask just in case an odd string leads her to me."

"Your—daughter? I don't know a Witch Wiskeria, please."

Sasi shivered, hugging herself to try to keep warm. Belavierr nodded reasonably.

"Fair. She was fourteen, last I saw her. Time has flown away, so it has been years since I saw her. She left a letter telling me not to follow. Out of respect—and because I am busy—I agreed. If you see her, please remember me to her and ask her if she will return home."

"I—I will?"

"Good. That was mere favor, not a question, so I take it as a kindness, lady. Question the second: do you know how the dead have once again walked amongst the living? It is of great interest to me."

Belavierr leaned down, and Sasi's mouth shut. It quivered—and she felt it now.

This woman was no friend of hers. If she had not heard the strange questions—where was her daughter? Time flown away? The greatest [Witch] living?

She would have still known Belavierr was dangerous simply because of those unsettling eyes. They were all wrong. They made Sasi feel sick to

look at—and she somehow knew about the ghosts.

Sasi wanted to turn and run for Grishen. To call the woman's name or Arteis'—but she found her feet were rooted. Rooted in Belavierr's shadow. And her mouth...she tried to keep it shut, but something was forcing it open.

Three questions. Sasi began to speak unwillingly and felt a terror as she began babbling.

“My father and mother are dead. A [Necromancer] killed them. He opened the Tomb of Afiele and besieged our town. I was nearly killed, and he nearly died, but then the ghosts came and helped kill him. I don't know why or how, but Ser Dalius was in the crypt ever so long, and the old Tombwarden vanished, and Paladin Arteis thought something was wrong—but doesn't know why. Only that when Culin called, the ghosts answered when they heard. And now they've pledged loyalty to him and me.”

She kept speaking, spilling out a rough recounting of the events of two months ago as Belavierr listened. The [Witch]'s face was puzzled, but she seemed to get a lot despite the jumbled explanation coming out of Sasi's mouth. Only when she held up a hand did Sasi, panting, finally fall silent.

“Ah. An old story. Death. Necromancers. Vengeance. Ghosts honoring their wills. Still 'tis strange to me. Why would they have made a pact...? Ah, well, perhaps they feared the dead might give orders once again. At least they are still around. Hopefully my business is left as it is. It is just large enough now, and I am so busy...”

She was musing to herself. Sasi listened earnestly now and knew the [Witch] had one question left. Belavierr tapped her lips.

“Strange though. 'Tis strange. I fear I've lost track of things. My daughter left, and it was five years before I read her letter sitting upon my table. The dead walk as ghosts, but I see so few souls. I have not seen a Dryad in oh so long, and I am starved of great bargains and old power. Is it somewhere else? Or is this all the world is? Crumbs and scraps instead of feasts for me?”

Belavierr sighed, long and loud.

“At least my home is righted. Perhaps then, once my business flourishes, I can send more servants to bring Wiskeria to me. Then I can finally weave her first immortality. That silly girl will die, else. She runs away, you see.”

She confided in Sasi, bending over to whisper.

“All because her little friend was hurt by me. She claims it was all my fault when I did him a great favor. Children. Such silly things. With respect, Lady Sasi.”

“P-please let me go, Witch Belavierr. What are you doing to me?”

The woman gave Sasi a puzzled glance as she straightened.

“Nothing. We have simply made a small pact. Three questions for three. You...ah. Children. You see, Lady Sasi, once we make a bargain, it must be fulfilled. That is the heart and nature of [Witches]. Now, I have one last question for thee. For you, I mean.”

She chuckled low, then, and Sasi was shaking. The moons seemed halted in the air...and she felt like the clouds were still. Belavierr adjusted her hat.

“Plenty of time between you and me without yon ghosts to interfere. I wonder why I levelled. Puzzling. Puzzling. The world is going so *fast*...am I spread out? My home has so many threads. And my pact here—it is taxing me.”

Another sigh. Then she turned, noticed Sasi, and gave her a wide and suddenly overly friendly smile. Almost like someone trying to be liked. Like a [Trader] trying to sell her mother something.

A business-smile. It was so *odd* on her face that it was terrifying in a completely different way. But Belavierr then lowered her head—and whispered a nightmare into Sasi’s ear.

“For my last question: Lady Sasi. What would you give me to bring your father and mother back to ye?”

Sasi's heart stopped dead in her chest. She swayed—and would have fallen but for the magic keeping her upright.

“Wh-what did you say?”

“I said—”

Belavierr seemed put out, as if she truly thought that Sasi hadn't heard. She raised her voice, and the earth rumbled as if echoing her voice.

“What will you give me to bring your parents back to you, Sasi?”

The [Witch] peered at Sasi.

“I can make you a replica or make a body and fill it just like you wanted them to be. Or if you wish—I can try to bring them back.”

She paused and looked around, frowning.

“—Though in this land, the souls are so difficult to find. And I still cannot find...many. But for you, I will call them back and return your every fee if I fail.”

She paused, then added grudgingly.

“I have not often failed. But it has happened more often than not lately. Another annoyance, regardless of whether or not it is Noelictus or any other land. But I offer refunds for failure. Rare as it may be.”

Sasi was not listening to the odd way she touted her skills. She was staring at Belavierr.

“Impossible. Impossible. You can't—bring people back from the dead. No one can.”

There were old stories about it. Someone going on a quest to find a way to revive someone. But no one could—Belavierr just sighed.

“Children. Of course I can, Lady Sasi. In one form. Puppet? A better version?”

Sasi knew she should run or refuse, but what came out of her mouth was just—the truth. And of course if someone offered it to her...

“No. Bring them back for me. I’ll give you anything. *Please.*”

The Stitch-Witch smiled hugely and held out a hand.

“Excellent. What shall you offer me?”

“*Anything.*”

Sasi reached for the hand without a thought. She looked at Belavierr.

“My soul? Anything. Just—*bring them back.*”

She reached for those long hands and knew Arteis and Grishen and Seraphel and everyone would have stopped her. But Belavierr just met Sasi’s eyes—

—*And jerked her hand back before the girl could take it.*

“Your soul? Child. It would be one for two. Not so fast. I said—what do you have to offer me? The services of your army of ghosts? The armies of the dead? The artifacts of the fields? Give me a list.”

She licked her lips eagerly. But Sasi...hesitated.

“I can tell Paladin Arteis to serve you.”

Belavierr’s brows knotted, then she looked around and for some reason stared at the keep. Sasi saw no light or movement, and Belavierr shook her head.

“They are bound by oath—but not greater powers—to you. They would not answer me. No good. Besides, there are but two hundred. Give the *armies*

of Afiele to me. Or the bones of your dead. How many hundreds of thousands? At least five—no, at least three.”

Three hundred thousand bodies? Sasi hesitated, but again—

“Okay. Take them.”

Again, she reached for the hand, but Belavierr hesitated before jerking her hand back.

“...I should need to see them rise, first. Very cunning. I almost took you for a proper child. But I want to see them march. If they’re in bad condition, I will want at least five hundred thousand. Not three.”

“March? You mean—like undead?”

“No, with souls and all. Aha, another clever trick. It seems I must speak with a serpent’s tongue, so let us negotiate over intonation first. Then the heart of it.”

Belavierr seemed to smile for a second—until she read Sasi’s blank look.

“...Did you mean just bodies? No, I want them all. Ghosts’ service. Or the dead with souls. For your family. Come, come, I’ll offer a hundred thousand for one. Two hundred thousand bodies *with* souls for two lives. It may be a high number—but few can match my services. Much less accept payment like this. A [Necromancer] isn’t half as subtle as I am. They’ll just stuff your parents in a half-revived body, trust me.”

A [Necromancer] to bring back the dead? Actually revive...? Sasi shook her head.

“I don’t care what it costs. Just bring them back? I don’t know how to wake the Tomb of Afiele. Just the ghosts. How do I...? Tell me? I’ll do it. *Please.*”

This time, Belavierr gave Sasi a look as odd and searching as the girl’s, both looking for a lie. And Belavierr slowly backed up.

“You *cannot* bring back the dead? But the ghosts...you said they came back to you.”

“For Culin, they said. They heard him. Not because of me.”

“Oh.”

Then the [Witch] looked troubled and concerned. Sasi reached for her, but Belavierr jerked her hand back.

“I see. That—is an issue. Do you have a relic, then? A great artifact to trade me?”

“No, but all the gold in Afiele—whatever you want!”

“Gold? How much? An ocean?”

“I don’t—I have a few thousand pieces, I think.”

“Of gold? Truegold? Gold Dragon’s scales? Or do you mean...just golden coins? Pure, twenty-four carat gold coins? A few thousand *pounds* of twenty-four carat gold and I could perhaps make a puppet for you.”

Belavierr was adjusting her prices, but Sasi just shook her head.

“No, gold coins. Like...”

She actually had one in her belt pouch. Belavierr peered at the coin, and her face fell.

“That isn’t real gold. It’s just a coin.”

“Yes. How much do you want? I can—I can get a loan?”

“...No. No, this is all wrong. This...now I realize it, have I come before the funeral? It is so silent, this land. Have I disturbed the burying? That would be an impoliteness, and I would apologize.”

Belavierr was backing up, looking around, and the strange woman seemed—concerned. As if she were suddenly out-of-place, disconcerted. She seemed let down by Sasi’s offers. Sasi *knew* Afiele was poor.

But she had expected a thousand pounds of pure gold? Truegold? Sasi was getting desperate.

“No, wait! We’ve already buried my parents, but—does that matter?”

Belavierr turned, and her eyes narrowed. Suspiciously. As if suspecting *she* were being the one tricked.

“Truly? Either you are a [Liar] of great talent or...but that is all wrong.”

“Why?”

*Had they done something wrong? Grishen had organized it, but—*Belavierr lifted her hat with one hand and ran a hand through her hair, perplexed as could be.

“The Lord of the Fields is dead. The Kingdom of Shade has lost a son and daughter. This you tell me. But where are the lamentations that ring from the hills? Where is the oath of vengeance upon every tongue? Where lieth his foe? Those ashy bones?”

She stared at where Feren’s skeleton had been vanished.

“For a Lord of the Fields? That little corpse’s living master?”

Now she looked so incredulous that Sasi grew angry.

“He was a monster who raised thousands of dead from Afiele’s crypts! Even a Zombie Giant!”

“Only one? No—my apologies.”

Belavierr saw Sasi’s eyes flashing and ducked her head. But she looked around, mystified.

“You did bury him?”

“We did! We mourned and sang at his grave!”

Tears were in Sasi’s eyes. Belavierr shook her head wonderingly.

“I did not hear the mountains weep. Nor the rivers rise up in tears. Did the dead not take a knee?”

“They did. The ghosts did.”

Sasi whispered. Again—she met that strange [Witch]’s eyes. And Belavierr shook her head.

“No, child. Not just a few hundred ghosts. I said—*did the dead not all rise and take a knee?* The countless dead of Afiele’s crypts? *That* is how it should be.”

Then Sasi realized Belavierr truly was old, as old as Arteis, and far scarier. She stopped reaching for the woman’s hand and halted.

“Who are you? Really?”

The [Witch] gave Sasi a look that was as old as time and, perhaps, worried. Because she seemed to realize *she* was out of touch.

“As I said, girl. Stitch-Witch. Belavierr. Ask—and someone will surely remember me. Ask a Dragon. Ask a Djinni. *Ask an immortal or even a half-Elf, and if they are old, they will know of me.*”

She stepped back and seemed to *rise*, a great shadow in the fields, and the scarecrows stared up at her and the wind blew. Then—Sasi remembered the stories of monsters who offered people anything and just returned terrible tricks.

“You—you’re an enemy, aren’t you? An enemy of Afiele?”

Belavierr glanced down at Sasi. Her eyes flickered, and the [Lady] tensed, but Belavierr just chuckled.

“Me? ‘Twould be a fine thing, girl, to be thought of forevermore and always as just enemy. I have been foe and ally, savior and villain. *Sometimes* your land’s enemy. But for all you sometimes greet me with steel, not always. I suppose...in this moment, what would you have me be?”

She tipped her hat up, and her eyes glowed ominously. Sasi’s mouth went dry, and Belavierr smiled coldly.

“Be very careful, girl, how you name me. Trust that I came to you earnestly to bargain. I did not expect...you cannot meet my price. I shall leave it there. I have learned enough. Strange. Something is *wrong*, and I have not realized it at my task. But the pact holds. Tell them that. They honor it, and so long as they do, I am content. But you and I cannot do business, it seems.”

She turned, clearly disappointed, and Sasi raised a hand, stepped after her.

“Wait! Don’t go! You said you could bring my parents back! Were you lying to me?”

If only she was. Sasi would have cursed her and screamed, but Belavierr turned back once, and her look was cold yet, somehow, the tiniest bit sympathetic. But her voice was like a dagger plunging into Sasi’s heart.

“Don’t be silly, girl. It would be kinder if I lied. The truth? It is not impossible for *me*. But you cannot meet my price, even with your ghosts. I apologize. But if you should come into a fortune...”

Her eyes glinted.

“I often find my clients. Good night, Lady Sasi.”

Then Belavierr stepped into the field, and Sasi ran after her. She pushed the Ashwheat aside, chasing after that dress, determined to grab her, but Belavierr was a step too fast. Sasi lunged—hit the ground—and when she rose, the Stitch-Witch was gone.

Leaving only another terrible, haunting memory. Sasi cried out—and then the fields lightened. She looked up, and a blazing sword descended.

“To arms! To arms, ghosts! Lady Sasi! Where is—”

Paladin Arteis landed, blasting from the direction of the keep. The ghost swung around—then grabbed Sasi.

“I felt the [Witch]’s presence and shot here the moment I sensed her. Which foe was that? To arms, I said! Dalius, secure Culin! The rest of you, to me, to me!”

She roared, and ghosts were in the air, shouting the alarm as Duchess Grishen and the mortal folk of House Ladel woke. Sasi felt Arteis looking around, and she only realized later that she had met another legend.

Belavierr, the Stitch-Witch. A story so terrible that Grishen refused to even speak of her until morning and her hand shook as she told Arteis never to leave Sasi’s side. A monster supposed to be dead.

Was she responsible for it all? Sasi didn’t sleep for two days. Not just for fear. She was drowning in that [Witch]’s terrible bargain. Wishing she could pay it.

But the times had long-changed. Armies of the dead? Dryads?

That [Witch] was as old as ghosts. Older. And she had seemed—confused, as frightening as she was. As if everything was wrong and the Afiele she knew today was not the same as her memories.

Seraphel

The City of Repose was a famous holiday destination for nearby kingdoms. From Pheislant, Avel, Samal, people came to enjoy themselves in the gloomy lands of Noelictus.

Perhaps it was that contrast—even Shardele, Seraphel’s eldest sister, had spoken fondly of Menorome.

And she was usually higher than the clouds on Dreamleaf. Seraphel was not exactly kind to her sisters. She loved them. At times. For appropriate periods.

But they were [Princesses] and used to sniping at each other. Her parents were also like that. Seraphel feared her mother, and her father was often distant, if dedicated to running his kingdom. She had thought people were like that in their private lives until she went visiting close friends.

Lord Lantal's family had deserved better.

Seraphel still felt like she had been on a strange, terrible adventure in a faraway land, nevermind that Afiele was in Noelictus. Menorome was everything she had expected. A safe, modern city on par with the Eternal Throne, Calanfer's own capital.

"It's not as good as the Eternal Throne, Your Highness. But second-best!"

That was Mariel's pronouncement after three days in Menorome, and it was as good as saying that this was her favorite city she'd ever been to. Nothing could beat the Eternal Throne, with its walkways of shining stone. The Eternal Throne had been built out of a relic from the time of legends.

Menorome was nearly as old as those legends in itself. The hanging candles shining at night—it was always night, here—the fascinatingly unique diversions—

Seraphel wished she could have said she enjoyed it all without reservation. But she missed Culin and Sasi. In fact, she wrote her first letter to them three days after getting to Menorome.

...I do not know if you are touring Afiele, but I have paid a Courier to bring you the latest selection of treats from the city. I hope you will share them without fighting and with your beloved subjects. Are you going to visit Menorome soon? I only inquire because I am sure I shall soon meet Lord Fallien of Ovela for our delayed nuptials. If providence aligns, we shall meet in the capital.

I should like that very much. My fondest thoughts for you both.

—Seraphel du Marquin

She left off her royal titles and finished the letter somewhat abruptly, embarrassed by the final two lines. Even if they were true, she felt it was so *intimate* that her mother would have had her burn it.

Royalty did not share thoughts that could be used against them, and even a Courier, the most expensive messenger you could hire, could open your letter.

Then again, they were paid to be so fast they could run a hundred miles in a day, fight off bandits, and even carry letters through wars. Seraphel rarely used them, but her parents had given her a lot of gold.

A hundred gold coins for a ‘simple delivery’ wasn’t that much. Right? It even included a return fee if Sasi and Culin wrote back within a day.

When Ser Dalimont, her most ‘elite’ bodyguard, heard that, he coughed deeply into one hand. His other arm was still healing from being broken, but he was moving it often to rebuild the muscle. Seraphel paused as Thistel added a few of her titles and sealed the letter for her.

“What, Dalimont? I know it’s expensive, but I bought a lot of sweets, and don’t you dare say they don’t deserve them! A City Runner would take a week or more; a Courier can do it in a day. Besides, I have the gold to spare.”

She frowned at him, wondering if he was going to talk her out of sending a letter. Dalimont eyed the pile of treats on the table.

Okay, perhaps Seraphel *had* bought so much it would only fit in a bag of holding. But she assumed the two children hadn’t had many sweets with Duchess Grishen around, and if they should have enough for a month and to share with anyone they visited...

Menorome had wonderful treats, including what they called ‘cracklebread’. Which was semi-doughy Ashwheat bread that you lit on fire to bake. In truth, the inner portion was already cooked, so you were just frying up the outside shell, and it blazed with numerous colors thanks to a dye that [Bakers] applied to it.

Seraphel had bought eighteen. She’d added two melons from Baleros, fat grapes from Chandrar, and a host of oranges, apples, and vibrant fruit from Izrilian orchards. The [Merchants] had been all-too-willing to procure it all for her. To that, she’d also put in spun sugar ‘candles’, which were filled with glowing powder: colored sugar. There were six pies, and Seraphel’s favorite was a sweetberry filling.

The venison pie was for Culin, who’d never had one. She then had bought a bunch of drinks, realizing that a Courier could bring them on time. So there was a thick, black-and-white swirl of something savory that tasted a bit like soot and cream—far better than it sounded—a flask of distilled flower nectar that she thought Sasi would like the idea of more than the taste...

In this way, Seraphel still forgot what she was. She had taken Afiele’s humbler fare in stride because nothing really matched the food she was used to in her palace with its rich cooking, but the amount of food the Courier was packing into his bag of holding was making the man hesitate.

Tobleden the Toad was his unflattering name, and he did have widely-spaced eyes that seemed to point in opposite directions. But he was a fast Courier who could *hop* over entire walls—and swim downriver at speeds most fish couldn’t match. He licked his lips with a long tongue now, and Seraphel wondered if his nickname referred to his actual class. Maybe he had the powers of a toad, somehow?

“Your Majesty, I’m sure any children would be sick with joy if you don’t mind me saying so. Fear not, even if I go by water, I’ll keep it all as dry as can be. Were you wishful of me waiting more’n a day?”

He was slightly wrong in how he called her ‘majesty’ instead of ‘highness’, and in other circumstances, the commonfolk addressing her directly would be a gaffe. But Couriers were allowed such things, and Seraphel smiled.

“A day will do, Courier Tobleden. And I believe you are free to set off—unless you have a comment, Dalimont?”

“—No, only that perhaps it would be best to fill Courier Toubleden’s bag of holding with a few more mundane goods if they were available, Your Highness. A few sacks of common apples or even *Yellats* wouldn’t hurt.”

He looked at the Courier, and Tobleden checked it.

“I could fit three more sacks in, but then my bag of holding will explode.”

“Ordinary apples? These are fine ones from House Quellae’s orchards in Izril, Dalimont. And why *Yellats*?”

Seraphel scoffed, and the [Knight] bent his head to whisper as the [Maids] struck up a sudden chatter, asking Tobleden for an autograph. Dalimont’d signaled them covertly, and he whispered.

“—Because Afiele needs common foods, Princess. Sending gold wouldn’t hurt either. Remember, it is in dire need of funds.”

“Oh.”

Seraphel remembered the way Lantal’s keep had been so run down. She looked at the pile of expensive treats—and bit her lip.

“Er, Courier Toubleden, perhaps some apples or such *would* be...”

“Would you purchase as much as you could hold, Courier? This will cover the costs. And I shall amend your delivery with a sum of several hundred gold coins, to be confirmed by the local Runner’s Guild.”

The Courier nodded seriously as Ser Dalimont found more gold, and Tobleden produced a piece of paper.

“You’re going to want me to confirm how much gold gets there? The Runner’s Guild in Menorome will check with the one in Afiele that I did the delivery right. I can buy them apples. Alright, if that’s all, I promise a full

delivery by morning of next day at the *latest*. Courier's honor. It's a delight to meet such a famous [Princess], Your Majesty Seraphel."

He gave her a bow, and Seraphel blinked at him.

"Me, famous? Whatever for?"

"Oh, er—well, many folk know Princess Seraphel of Calanfer. I, uh, just meant it'll be a story to tell my colleagues. Especially with the upcoming wedding!"

Tobleden floundered, and Seraphel's smile grew strained as she realized what he meant. *The Cursed Princess of Calanfer, the infamous widower.*

About to be wed once more. Dalimont gave the Courier a severe look, and he retreated fast.

That sucked the good mood out of Seraphel. And like that, her frenzy of gift-buying ended and her enjoyment of Menorome faded.

The city was beautiful. But Seraphel just wasn't able to enjoy it.

She was about to be married again, and every time she began to relax, she was reminded of that fact by a Courier, gossip, or just her own knowledge of time ticking down.

It didn't help that she was pretty sure this was a marriage of pure convenience and her would-be husband, Lord Fallien of Ovela, did not care for a thrice-wed [Princess]. *Used goods* was how her sister Aielef had once referred to her in earshot.

It was apt for a [Princess]. They were never so valuable as when they were first wed, and unless Seraphel became a [Queen]—highly unlikely in any nation—she was only useful in keeping relations strong between her husband and home.

“Cheer up, Princess. Shall we go visit a Sleeping Parlor next? I’ve wished to visit, and it may make your day.”

Thistel did her best to make Seraphel feel better. Seraphel trailed along listlessly as her [Knights] cleared the way through the streets for her. She stood out, she knew, with her colorful dawn-styled dress and her shining escort.

If only she matched her reputation. She would like to be some [Cursed Princess], a Level 48 nightmare who actually murdered her husbands.

But she was just a Level 18 [Princess]; one did not get levels from being divorced. You levelled by fulfilling your class. Seraphel had levelled twice times during the siege, probably because surviving threats to your life was a very [Princess]-like thing to do.

But she hadn’t done much. She wasn’t that impressive in levels. And Level 18 already put her above most of her siblings. Compared to any *real* class, though...

She had been Level 14 when she was fifteen years old. In the intervening decade since, she had levelled twice. That was as good an explanation for how Seraphel felt about her personal progression.

“Your Majesty! Can we tempt you with a Sleeping Parlor?”

“Your Highness of Calanfer! I have an attraction for you—there’s a [Fortune Teller] who knows you and she have a meeting ordained—”

“Something to whet your appetite? Any treat, from anywhere in—”

Seraphel was used to being called out to, so she ignored most of the people trying to get something from her. Thistel was the one who flitted from spot to spot, asking what each thing was.

“So what is a Sleeping Parlor? Why would Her Highness want it?”

She asked one eager [Shop Attendant], who babbled as fast as she could.

“Oh, the Sleeping Parlors are a delight, Miss! Please tell Her Majesty that it’s where you can sleep even if you have the worst insomnia as many visitors to Menorome have. You call it odd to be in the night so long when it’s better than day!”

She pointed above with a laugh, and Seraphel saw a blazing line of green lights, illuminating this entire street like some kind of glade of greens, and even brown flames. It felt like walking through some kind of phantasmal woods if you stared up. Still, it was odd never seeing the sun. The attendant went on as someone tried to get around one of her Thronebearers.

“Your Majesty! Your Majesty, I have good luck charms for—”

“The Sleeping Parlors let you fall asleep in moments or doze to your heart’s content! Have you never felt the sensation of lying abed and not wishing to wake? Imagine doing that long as you wished! Or—if you care to rest fully, we offer *dreams*. Pleasant dreams, dreams of adventure, even more... interesting dreams.”

“Interesting?”

Thistel was getting too into the sales-pitch. The shop-attendant whispered to her, and Seraphel could just guess what she was saying to make her [Maid] blush and giggle. Seraphel rolled her eyes.

“Ah, so *that’s* why it’s so popular. Noelictus sells dreams.”

“Not a bad thing to sell, Your Highness.”

Dalimont commented neutrally. Seraphel hesitated.

“Yes, well—I haven’t dreamed often since I was a girl.”

“Neither have I. Perhaps there’s something to it, then.”

The [Princess] tapped her lips thoughtfully. She nodded at Dalimont. Before the siege of Afiele, she had treated him like any [Knight]—poorly and with considerable disdain since he was just there to send her to another wedding and stand guard until relieved.

Now, though, she knew him by name and considered him a confidant, someone she might be able to trust not to report everything she said back to her mother, Ielane. Indeed, Dalimont seemed to be taking his job more seriously, and not just because of the [Necromancer] attack. He turned his head and snapped left.

“Dame Neranthei. Tighten your formation.”

One of the younger Thronebearers blushed and tried to keep the people flocking around Seraphel back. The Thronebearers were good at crowd control, but there were so many people pressing in...

Well, they were also on the lookout for [Assassins] and the like. But in this case, Dame Neranthei was being beset by a particularly ornery [Shopkeeper].

He *must* have been high-level, because he was actually managing to *push* forwards despite the woman literally planting her feet and shoving him back.

“Your Highness! I’ve got good-luck charms! Made by masterful [Enchanters]! Enough to bring you fortune and good health!”

Seraphel ignored him, looking around and never seeming to see him in perfect [Princess] form. You never won by acknowledging these people, and Dalimont strode over to push the man back.

“Back up! Her Highness is not to be accosted! Back up or I shall call for the Watch, sir!”

The [Shopkeeper] really did think he had a goldmine in Seraphel. Perhaps her spending spree had been noticed, because somehow he fought *both* Thronebearers, pushing himself forwards. He had a weaselly face and that smile that said he thought he was being charming—while even Seraphel could see the contempt he had for her in his eyes.

“Your Highness—let go of me! She’ll want to hear—[Irresistible Offer]! Your Highness, I have charms that can end any curse, even for your

upcoming wedding!”

Seraphel’s head slowly turned, and her escort stopped. The street quieted a second, and Thistel broke off from talking with the sleep attendant.

“My *curse*?”

Everyone looked at the Cursed Princess of Calanfer, and Seraphel saw the [Shopkeeper]’s oily smile.

“You may have tried to halt it before, Your Highness—but you’ve never held Drathian jade before. It comes from the western archipelago, spelled by their strange magicks! Come to my stall and see—”

“*Enough!*”

Dalimont snapped and grabbed the man’s arm. He raised his voice.

“Using a Skill on royalty? I shall have the Watch upon you! Back *up!* Now!”

He unsheathed an inch of his sword, and that made many of the hangers-on scatter. The Thronebearers closed ranks, but the [Shopkeeper] was staring at Seraphel. He thought he’d struck a nerve.

And he had. But instead of fear or anxiety—Thistel backed up a step. Mariel whispered.

“Oh no, Your Highness—”

There was something that Menorome didn’t know of Seraphel. She had been on her best behavior with Afiele because she liked Lord Lantal. She had been charmed by the rural county and had little to actually make her angry aside from the [Necromancer]. Okay, she’d been bored, but the people had been genuinely kind.

But *Menorome* was like Calanfer, and the hangers-on, the snide remarks—what people forgot was this:

Before becoming the Cursed Princess, famous for her dead husbands more than anything else, Seraphel du Marquin had earned her reputation as a girl for something completely different. It was still another, unofficial nickname within the palace.

Seraphel the Sharptongued. She might have few Skills that could help rule a nation. None to save a brave man or stop undead. A useless [Princess] she might be to rule—but a [Princess] in court?

Seraphel's head turned, and she regarded the weasel-faced [Shopkeeper]. She thought for two seconds in the silence, then replied.

“Sir Shopkeeper. Your loud and braying remarks about my ‘curse’ are not well-taken. Out of courtesy to you, I would visit your stall—”

His expression had become pleased when she acknowledged him, then puzzled when he realized she was insulting him. He was drawing breath to engage, but Seraphel just spoke over him.

“—but any [Shopkeeper] who thinks he can cure my curse while having a face like *that* is clearly selling snake-oil. Or perhaps it's not a curse? Unfortunate, either way.”

Her voice was loud, carried clear down the street despite the other noise, and it elicited a loud titter of laughter from everyone who heard it. The unlucky [Shopkeeper] turned red.

“My—”

He was not prepared for Seraphel's wrath. [Carrying Remark]. [Conversation: I Strike First]. And...[Insight: Personal Anxiety]. Seraphel's eyes flashed.

“Your halitosis? I didn't wish to say, but I smelled it from here. Perhaps you should look into breath tonics, sir? Or join the Adventurer's Guild. I imagine you could lay low most foes by exhalation alone. *Please, sir. I pray thee stop speaking or I might swoon.*”

She put a hand to her forehead dramatically—and the man’s red face turned white. He staggered as Dalimont let him go, and the Thronebearer even gave the man a sympathetic look.

People had observed the unlucky shopkeeper, and a few were even pinching their noses, perhaps smelling or attributing bad breath to him. He stood there, poleaxed, as Seraphel walked onwards quickly, as if trying to get downwind of him.

Poor man. His reputation had to be hit from that one. The [Princess] dressing you down in public was a blow, but to be fair, she was royalty aiming down. The problem was that Seraphel’s Skills meant that the public took her side.

And—the man was more than merely embarrassed. He actually sagged backwards as Seraphel’s final Skill hit him.

[Dizzying Rebuke]. He tried to retort or shout at her, form an insult, but he was so sick he actually bent over for a second. Seraphel waited.

“Hurry up, everyone. I think I hit him hard. I think he’s going to—ah.”

He began puking behind her, to the disgust of the street. Mariel hurried out of the way with a cry of disgust, clutching at her skirts, and the man’s day was well and truly ruined.

Seraphel walked on, feeling...well, better. She knew it was cruel, but she was so good at throwing comments back that even her sisters walked clear of her.

“...I thought I wouldn’t see Her Highness shooting enchanted bolts from her tongue in my time with her. Or if I did, I feared it would be me.”

After a few minutes, Dalimont dared to speak. Seraphel turned her head to him and looked mock-outraged.

“I never used my Skill on you, Dalimont. I *was* considerate, you know. I only gave you the rough side of my tongue, not the full force of my Skills.

Besides, my days of infamy are long gone.”

She heard a snort and turned to glare at her [Maids]. They looked innocent, and Ser Dalimont bowed slightly.

“Would that I had seen you as a [Princess] when you were younger, Princess Seraphel. Might I dare to ask if the rumors are true that you once insulted a young Marquess so much she also threw up in a salad bowl?”

Seraphel turned faintly red. Yes, she had been a Level 16 [Princess] as a child. The most talented of her siblings—for a time.

[Princess of Rebukes]. She’d had an entire class devoted to her ability to insult someone or find their weak-points in conversation.

“I felt terrible afterwards, Dalimont. Those days are long past. I am on my best behavior.”

“Yes...so I see.”

“I’m getting it out of my system, Dalimont! Before I visit the Throne of Shadows. Trust me, I will be sweet as those sugar-candles in court.”

Seraphel promised and meant it. She sighed, thinking of her husband.

“—And to my husband, Lord Fallien. Do you think he truly dislikes me?”

He hadn’t visited her in Afiele, and when the siege had begun—well, she understood he had sent troops and even prepared to go himself, but when the [Necromancer] was slain, he’d begged the affairs of Ovela in his brief notes to her.

Not a missive or representative. She didn’t even know his face aside from a few paintings of him as a boy. She knew his reputation as a high-level [Lord] who was good at war, and his twin sister was competing for his position...but she feared he truly had no taste for her.

Dalimont bowed his head.

“I cannot speak for Lord Fallien. To be honest...his actions indicate you are likely right and he regards you as more of a means to an end.”

“Ser Dalimont!”

Mariel and the other Thronebearers were scandalized. That was *not* something you told a [Princess] to be wed. But Seraphel just nodded and closed her eyes.

“Thank you for being truthful, Dalimont. I think you are correct. As for the rest of you—*shut up*. I have no patience for your fake smiles at this moment. I know all your names, and I’ll remember your insincerity.”

That shut them up. Dalimont coughed into his gauntleted hand again.

“—I only meant to say that in Lord Fallien’s defense, his lands *are* constantly locked in strife with Ailendamus. As far as my reports on him go, the ‘skirmishes’ in Ovela mirror a true war, and his only returns to the capital are to raise more manpower. It is still lax of him, but it is something to bear in mind.”

“So he has a good excuse. I shall reserve judgment. Besides, it’s not my first wedding. And the royal family wishes to see me. *Dire*.”

Seraphel shuddered as she walked through Menorome. She was no fan of meeting foreign monarchs. They were often—erratic. Dalimont ducked his head.

“You are due tomorrow in the palace. Would you like to spend your day anywhere else?”

“Oh—I’m not in the mood to sleep after taking down that odorous little rat. Take me somewhere *interesting*, Dalimont. A real sight of Menorome. And remind me about the royal family. I know their names, of course, and a bit of their personalities, but each royal is different.”

Dalimont conferred with Dame Neranthei for a second, and she suggested something that had him leading them the way they’d come—only down a

different street. Back towards the center of the city, called Sovereign District. Seraphel saw their destination, a huge, rounded dome that sat as one of the taller buildings besides the palace itself.

Black stone palace, like some evil tyrant's lair out of a storybook. But the candles lit it well enough...and the domed building was far, far more colorful. In fact, it was bestrewn with colorful cloth like there was a celebration happening, and Seraphel saw posters tacked up to walls the closer they got.

“What is that building, Dalimont? And all that cloth...is that a fire hazard with the candles?”

The Thronebearer hesitated.

“I’m told Menorome *does* have a number of fires, but many candles are magical, Princess. As for the building—that is the Synphasia Theatre.”

“Oh! The one with performers. Is...do you think Cara is there? Have you heard of her?”

Seraphel looked around anxiously, and the other girl she really wanted to meet was on her mind. But she hadn’t seen nor heard of Cara—and she had expected to.

Dalimont’s smile was sly. Seraphel’s eyes opened wide.

“Wait, is she actually there? *Dalimont! You should have said at once—!*”

“My understanding is that she *just* became one of the performers, Your Highness. I heard she joined the performances. We may be able to track her down there. It’s rather impressive. The Synphasia hosts some of the best performers in the region at times. Barelle the Bard has played there. At other times...it’s less auspicious.”

The most famous [Bard] in the world was Barelle the Bard and his magical harp. Seraphel strode faster, talking more excitedly.

“Well, Cara of all women would find her way there. Can we get a ticket?”

“For you, Your Highness? Of course. The cost is nominal...to you. It’s harder to get a seat at short notice, but, er, I have heard that the Synphasia’s tickets are much reduced in prices. I had a royal box for you for sixteen gold coins.”

“...Is that high or low?”

Wasn’t that some families’ yearly wages? Seraphel wasn’t sure, but Dalimont coughed.

“—In other times, they could ask for ten times that, Your Highness. There’s no Barelle performing right now.”

“There’s Cara.”

“Yes, but she would be *new*. I meant established talent. The closest they have is one ‘Rolairenes the Violinist’. Said to be as good as any top performer, actually, but erratic. Normally, the Synphasia has many, *many* high-level performers. Most have gone to Ailendamus, who endorses the arts.”

“Huh. Well...I don’t quite care so long as we see Cara.”

Seraphel was smiling already. She walked faster, and Dalimont took this moment to gesture Dame Neranthei to step forwards.

“Whilst we find a seat, your royal parents did have a small dossier prepared for you, Seraphel.”

The [Princess] sighed gustily.

“You clever wretch, Dalimont. I’m in a good mood, and now I have to work? *Fine*, report, Neranthei. What do I have to say or do?”

It was the custom of King Reclis, often called the King of Diplomacy, to send reports to his offspring that they might avoid gaffes and pursue his wishes abroad.

The dossiers were both character studies on a particular ruler and ways to ingratiate yourself to them. In this case, he hadn't given Seraphel more instructions than 'be charming', which was easy.

She did have practice. Seraphel had met and talked to eleven other monarchs for extended periods of time. Often just socializing over a banquet or greeting them, but she was no child to freeze up or embarrass herself.

Again, of the seven [Princesses] of Calanfer, Seraphel was the fourth-oldest and decent at being, well, sociable.

She did have a sharp tongue, but she never used it on royalty. If anything, her elder sister, 3rd Princess Aielef, had a worse temper at times.

In order, excluding Seraphel, they were:

1st Princess Shardele, airheaded, fond of Dreamleaf and charming enough, but lazy.

2nd Princess Menisi, probably the most rebellious of the seven, truly scary if you were on her bad side. She'd essentially been married away to keep her out of the public eye.

3rd Princess Aielef, arrogant, prideful, and bad-tempered. Seraphel's personal rival of the lot, at times, given how they'd grown up together.

5th Princess Vernoue, the bookish one who studied magic and wouldn't shut up about wanting to become a [Mage].

6th Princess Lyonette, the second-worst of the lot. Bratty, insisted on calling anyone who wasn't at least aristocracy a 'peon', and currently a runaway from the palace.

And lastly, the 7th Princess, young Ellet, a girl of 13 who was innocent, earnest, doted on by her entire family, and had not yet developed objectionable traits. She would...but Seraphel cherished the moments while she could wholeheartedly like Ellet.

Not that Seraphel would meet any of them, but it was telling that she was one of the more capable ones in court. When she chose to be.

“I know Alloreve is Kaazian. I won’t be surprised by his skin tone and ask if he’s Chandrarian like Aielef once did to that Hundredlord. Prince Seratoito has a girl’s name and Princess Kadane a boy’s. They had their names swapped when they were young?”

“I believe the story goes that Their Majesties decided to name their first two children Kadane and Seratoito, and Her Majesty insisted on giving the names in order, regardless of gender.”

“Now there’s a curious woman. Cathiel Nicterise. Do I call her Queen Cathiel? The style is to use last names, but we are royalty.”

“A remove would be acceptable until you have greeted each other or feel familiar, Your Highness.”

Neranthi suggested. Seraphel sighed.

“Duly noted. I’ve heard she’s—tough to deal with from Mother.”

“She’s unpredictable. King Alloreve will be the one who greets you, and he is cordial and charming. You may not even see Queen Nicterise.”

“Really? Well, I wouldn’t mind that. She can’t be that bad, can she? I’ve dealt with [Queens] before. My favorite was Queen Geilouna, you know.”

“The Sleeping Queen of Desonis? How was she, Your Highness? Did she really sleep all the time?”

Dame Neranthi was younger than Dalimont, and she grew excited at the famous ‘Bedtime Queen’ of the wet kingdom of Desonis. Dalimont glared at her for her breach of conduct, but Seraphel had survived the undead with all these Thronebearers, so she decided to gossip a tiny bit. She smiled at Neranthi.

“She did sleep most of the time she visited Calanfer. I heard she was abed till four in the evening each day! It’s no rumor she actually sleeps that

much. But she's quite charming. She even has one of those cute Sariant Lambs who sleeps with her. Er—how difficult are the royal family compared to Queen Geilouna, Dalimont? Use the Princess-system.”

The man hesitated.

“...The youngest child aside, Princess Kadane and Prince Seratoito are, er—eccentrics. I would rate them at a Lyonette-level of difficulty. Not quite Menisi.”

Seraphel bit her lip.

“That bad?”

“Not *always*. Prince Seratoito is a famed diplomat. Perhaps only Shardele in his case? You will hopefully not interact with them long. King Allorev? Why, he's purely Ellet, or so I've heard. A charming man.”

“...Queen Nicterise? Dalimont?”

He was tellingly silent. Then he murmured.

“*Either* a Vernoue or Shardele, quite, quite reasonable if sometimes scattered. Or...”

“Menisi?”

“Queen Ielane in a temper. Or worse, I've heard.”

Seraphel inhaled. That went *beyond* the Princess-scale of badness. She saw Mariel and Thistel looking worried, and Neranthei tried to reassure them all.

“You won't meet her in likeliness, Princess. And the odds of it being bad are low, or so I've heard. Come—let's see if the [Singer] is here. Your Highness, I truly did hear she appeared just a few days ago, when you did.”

“And Dalimont told you not to tell me so I'd have a treat before the palace. Typical.”

Seraphel snorted as they approached the Synphasia Theatre. She saw it had multiple entrances, like a coliseum, and there was a good amount of guests entering. Though—she did admit, it wasn't a rush.

Oh, and here were posters of the main act himself. She saw a handsome half-Elf, posing with a violin in a spotlight on a life-sized poster right by one of the entrances.

'See Rolairenes the Violinist! The immortal half-Elf without match! You shall never hear such perfection in music again!'

In the background were other performers, a [Juggler], a [Sword Dancer] who'd trained in Drath...Seraphel knew those acts, and they were fairly generic. Calanfer had plenty of entertainment.

“[Fools] performing japes, a bunch of performing dogs and a [Beast Master]...oh, that is weak, Dalimont. Mother wouldn't show this to a [Lord] for a guest, let alone royalty.”

If they were high-level, that would be advertised. Dalimont nodded as he gestured at Rolairenes.

“The half-Elf seems to be the draw. But, ah—yes, here it is. Look at this, Your Highness.”

He did know what interested her, and Seraphel peered at a little note near the bottom. Her lips quirked as she read it out loud.

“‘Two-third refund for no performance?’ Why does it say that?”

“I believe we may see, Your Highness. Oh, and there is another performer...”

He pointed, and Seraphel saw a tiny portrait in the top-right corner.

'Listen to Yoitha Sterngest, amazing and unique rhythms of sound! Marvel at the diversity of her creation!'

“...Is that the best they can write? No Cara anywhere to be found! She must be an unlisted act. Oh, well. Dalimont, secure our seats. The royal box, you said? At least I won’t have annoying pests.”

Seraphel was hopeful, regardless of the actual talent here. She strode into the Synphasia and was greeted by the manager almost instantly.

“Your royal Highness! It is an honor to have the 4th Princess of Calanfer here, in the Synphasia! Why, today is a day of royal prestige! Welcome, welcome—Ser Knight, your reserved seats are ready. Can I offer you refreshments or sustenance? If there is anything at all—”

He was an odd fellow. Seraphel didn’t speak, but let Dalimont deal with the unctuous man. He had curiously restless feet, some rather obvious makeup on, and too much personal cologne. But he knew she was the 4th Princess, and she whispered.

“Thistel, get us something decent to drink or eat. Don’t overspend.”

Her [Maid] brightened up and went to pay for some overpriced treats for the performance. Interestingly, Seraphel noted the [Manager] seemed rather nervous as he whispered to Dalimont.

“This way, Ser Knight, this way! Er...so you know, someone else has reserved the Royal Booths. And Rolairenes is hard at work preparing his masterpiece! I am sure he will be ready today.”

Dalimont slowed and frowned at both claims.

“The royal booth? *Her Highness* is present, man. Someone else may well rent it at other times, but the Order of Thronebearers cannot suffer Her Highness sitting next to commonfolk, no matter how well paying! We have an issue we must settle now. For security if not impropriety!”

“No, no, nonono—Ser Knight, it’s completely out of my hands! That is, I received both reservations, and I assure you, it is not improper! In fact, *His Majesty of Avel* was gracious enough to state there was room enough for both. And Rolairenes will perform! My word on it or—”

Why was he so worried about his performer not working? Was his violin broken or something? Then Seraphel heard who was sharing her booth, and her heart sank.

“Oh no. Not him.”

She almost turned and walked out, but Dalimont was whispering with the manager, and a name caught Seraphel’s ear.

“Is Singer Cara going to be performing?”

“Who? That—oh. Oh! Well—yes. We could have her—I’ll make sure of it, Ser Knight. If Her Highness wishes to hear her, hear her she shall! I’ll arrange it directly.”

Cara *was* here! Seraphel stopped, bit her lip, and saw Dalimont striding over.

“Your Highness, I apologize. We could reserve other booths, but His Majesty apparently arrived in the capital and made an impulse reservation. He agreed to allow us room, so the impetus...”

Politics. Seraphel closed her eyes. They couldn’t well run away from him. She could beg being busy and cancel, but Cara was *here*.

“No, I understand, Ser Dalimont. Let’s meet him. Argh. He will be at the palace, won’t he? Of all...”

It seemed work had come for her whether she liked it or not. Speaking of royalty...the King of Avel, Itreimedes, wasn’t the worst of men to deal with. He was actually easier than most.

It was just that he was a lot. And he never *stopped*.

“*Princess Seraphel!* It’s a delight to meet you again...we have met before, haven’t we? Calanfer? I don’t recall, but I’m sure we have. I’d do the royal

kiss, but I've been eating snacks—hello, welcome, and, er, congratulations on the wedding? I won't be attending. Urgent business and all that.”

King Itreimedes was as bad at social niceties as Lyonette. And his court was far more informal than Calanfer's. During his speech, Seraphel swore she saw one of his advisors kick him in the ankle. Twice.

In truth, you would either find Itreimedes a charming man or an obnoxious one with little middle ground. To paint the picture of him—he owned the Bow of Avel, the heirloom of the Hundred Heroes, signature weapon of Avel's kings.

He used the bow to scratch his back, pick things up, and sometimes as a doorstop. The weapon didn't break no matter how much he banged it around, but it was something to see him use a *Relic* of legends to try and smash a fly.

Itreimedes was careless, often flighty, and indulgent in things that he enjoyed—a poor ruler by some metrics, but he left his court to administer his kingdom, and there were worse places to be than Avel.

He was also overweight, and it was clear he'd been eating for at least half an hour as he sat in the royal booth. Seraphel took his hand, and it was sticky.

“Your Majesty is looking as vigorous as ever. I believe we did meet when I was a girl. You hunted in the Gaiil-Drome forests?”

Her [Perfect Recall] Skill helped, and Itreimedes snapped his fingers.

“Right! I nearly got in trouble with the half-Elves because they kept claiming my bow did all the shooting. Nevermind that I beat them. Hah! A royal hunt, and the Eternal Throne is one of my favorite places to be. A damn shame it's so far from Avel. I could go racing around the countryside again next time I visit.”

He hefted his bow with a grin and then glanced down at his somewhat more portly frame than the young man Seraphel remembered as a girl. She faintly

recalled having a crush on him...Itreimedes hesitated as he eyed his protruding belly.

“I’ve been taking it easy of late. No wars or such. But I’ll be fit again come summer.”

He gave her a self-confident smile that only slipped when one of his advisors, a balding man with a polished pate, muttered.

“There’s a claim I’ve heard for half a decade.”

“*Your Highness*, let me introduce you to my royal court. Kick them out of any seats you wish.”

Itreimedes glared at his advisors, and Seraphel saw the royal booth really was big enough for all of them. It hung over the other commonfolk, close to the stage, and they would have a prime view of any performances.

In truth, the best seats were probably dead-center in the middle, but royalty had to be aloof. Seraphel bowed again.

“I see there are plenty of seats. We will try not to disturb Your Majesty’s enjoyment.”

Itreimedes waved his bow in a laconic salute.

“Oh, well, thank you. I always visit The Synphasia when I’m here. This Rolairenes fellow is new, but the rest of the show looks dull as—I mean, I hope you enjoy. I’d better enjoy or I’ll make whoever suggested it visit every day until I leave.”

He glared around at his court, who actually shot back at him with scoffs and snide remarks. They were amusing, and Seraphel kept smiling until she found a seat as far away from him as possible.

She distinctly heard Itreimedes muttering in a quiet voice, much like her.

“Whew. There, I was polite! I didn’t say a *thing* about her curse. Dead gods, [Princesses] tire me out.”

It was odd to realize he was as reluctant to be proper as she was. Itreimedes wasn't married, but he probably had a refined aversion to being courted by most [Princesses]. He had nothing to fear from her, but Seraphel allowed that he might have met her sisters, in which case he was welcome to his distaste for socialization.

Anyways, she was here for Cara. Seraphel waited as the magical lights dimmed and inspected the Synphasia.

Theaters were not common in Terandria, much less public ones. This one was decent enough; faded upholstery showed that this had probably been a very high-class place at one point. It was still well-enough off, but there was wear-and-tear in the old cloth, and Itreimedes' comments suggested this place was past its heyday.

Certainly, the [Manager] seemed lower-level. Oh, he came out with flourishes, shouting his name, which Seraphel refused to remember, welcoming the two royal guests, who merely waved to the mostly full audience, and he announced the acts—but Seraphel had seen better.

Calanfer was better. Calanfer was famous for performances, and she *had* seen Barelle the Bard perform, once. He needed no fanfare or flashes of lights or tricks. He simply had to play one note from his magical harp, and his audience would sit up. A thrum would run through the ground and air, and then...

These performances were just the kind of thing you could see at any passing fair or menagerie or carnival. It was the kind of thing you'd see in a poorer nation's court, or a [Lord] or [Lady] would put on with a smaller budget and less experience. And it was both curious and boring to Seraphel.

The first act was Rolairenes the Violinist.

He did not come on stage. The [Manager] shouted his name—hurried backstage, then came back to bow with a huge, nervous smile at the royal booth.

“—*Rolaireness is tuning his violin!* In the interim, to start—we have Jeriseh, the Juggler, with his hundred knives!”

Then they brought out a Level 20-something [Juggler] who did indeed flick up a number of shiny blades that Seraphel doubted were that sharp, and she watched for about a minute before she got bored.

She'd seen it. She was more curious about why the half-Elf hadn't appeared. He was clearly here, and she sensed something was going on back-stage. But the show had to go on, so what the audience got was a [Juggler], a [Firebreather], a [Sword Dancer]—

Again, it wasn't *bad*. The [Firebreather] was the best Seraphel had seen, including the street-acts, and she actually blew a flare of fire that turned into a Wyvern that flew overhead. Seraphel felt the heat, and Dalimont's shield was raised in case of an accident—but it was just a trick.

The audience gasped and applauded, and Seraphel and Itremeides did too. But unlike children who saw the fire trick for the first time...Itreimedes and his court were whispering loudly to each other.

“They used to have a six-headed Hydra that four [Firebreathers] made. You could throw a bucket on it and run on stage. What happened to that?”

“They burnt down four blocks of the city, Your Majesty.”

“Ah, right. Damned shame.”

Seraphel had seen Archmage Viltach, visiting the Eternal Throne, conjure a pillar of magical flames fifty feet high. The trick was good, and if the other performances were on-par with that, she would have been dutifully entertained.

They were not.

The [Sword Dancer] leapt about the stage in fantastic displays of sword-cuts and feints and even brought on an assistant for a mock sword-fight. The [Mercenary] attacked and parried with a sword and shield in a

convincing display of ineptitude, trying to catch the whirling man with his twin swords.

“Even we could deal with that. He’s just nervous because he has no armor.”

Dame Neranthei and Ser Dalimont were commenting on the actual prowess of the [Sword Dancer]. Sure enough, the [Mercenary] wasn’t *that* good. And—he got a slash across one arm that shed actual blood.

That was dramatic and unintended, and they had to rush him off-stage. In the strained silence, the [Manager] came back.

“Rolaireness the Violinist is still tuning up! Yoitha is next! Prepare to be amazed!”

Someone had to mop up the blood. Ireimedes was commenting on how he could have taken both [Sword Dancer] and [Mercenary] on with just his bow, and Seraphel was hoping Cara appeared.

What should she say? Did Cara want to speak? She had said she needed to find her own way, but Seraphel wanted to...

She heard some of the audience members muttering in the unplanned break. It seemed some were regulars of the Synphasia, and Seraphel’s [Long Ear] let her hear more context.

“If Rolare doesn’t perform once this week, they’ll have to fire him.”

“And replace him with who? When he performs, I’m spellbound.”

“When. If he spends his time tuning his violin for an hour straight again, I won’t come back until he’s gone. Or I’ll throw something at him.”

“If you do, there’s no chance he’ll perform. Remember last time? Someone sneezed halfway into his music and he stormed off-stage.”

Now there’s a picky performer. Was he actually just tuning his violin and not performing because he was that touchy? Seraphel didn’t know—but she

realized she might not listen to him anyways because the *next* performer nearly chased her out of the theatre.

Tang tang thonk!

Yoitha Sterngest was a Dwarf. And her performance was what the manager had called ‘the edge of experimental music’ when he introduced her.

As far as Seraphel could understand, it was hitting a bunch of curious objects, from literal gongs to pieces of metal to a sponge, and producing a variety of sounds that you could generously call entertainment.

Not music. *This* was the sound that Seraphel had heard when she first entered Menorome, and it was bad. She turned her head and saw Itreimedes had his fingers in his ears and was trying to bury his face in one of the snack-bowls.

Even the Thronebearers, good at masking their expressions, winced. The desperate Dwarf on stage had bright blue hair, both her beard and hair clearly dyed. She wore colorful clothing, almost like a [Fool], and she had a polished pair of hammers she used to perform.

The worst part was that she was clearly conscious she was losing the audience. Noelictus citizens were politer than some that Seraphel had known; even in Calanfer, she would be getting boos, but the Dwarf serenaded them for five minutes—then switched into an odd performing routine.

“And now, my hammer tricks!”

“Oh no, she’s not done.”

Itreimedes groaned. Seraphel wasn’t sure if the Dwarf heard him from the booth; he was loud, but she almost stumbled as she fumbled her hammers up. She smacked them together overhead, and Seraphel decided she had to

step out for a second to use the privy or something. She winced at the noise—then saw Yoitha flip a hammer up.

It *spun* so fast and in such a perfect arc that it looked like a band of spinning, shining metal, not a hammer. It rose to the ceiling, nearly forty feet overhead—and fell straight down.

What an incredible toss! Seraphel paused, half-risen from her seat, and Ireimedes glanced up.

“Huh?”

Yoitha caught it. She flipped the other hammer up, and the people in the front row *ducked* nervously. But the hammer flashed up, rotating at such speed that Seraphel swore she felt a gust of wind.

That was—amazing! Yoitha caught the hammer again and bowed. She still looked nervous, but she got a few claps for that alone. Then she flicked *both* hammers up, caught them, and whirled one around in her hand as if it were a blade. She flicked it behind her, over her head, caught it, and then *tossed* both so hard that they seemed to rotate in the air right in front of her before she grabbed them.

What kind of Skill was that? Yoitha’s little card said ‘[Hammer Performer]’, not [Juggler]. And it wasn’t exactly juggling, but a weird way of tossing. The wrist strength you needed to throw a hammer like that was *high*. They looked solid, and Seraphel was eager to see what Yoitha did next.

Then she saw the Dwarf raise the hammers, smack them gently together in a *clang*—and bow.

Seraphel stared.

“...Was that it?”

The manager hurried on-stage, glaring as Yoitha practically ran off it.

“Yoitha Sterngest!”

There was muted applause, and Seraphel gave the fleeing Dwarf a mystified look. What was *that*? The weird hammering sounds were like something a bunch of nobles would demand for music and convince themselves was good art. It wasn't, and Calanfer knew better than to lean into abstraction for their performances.

As for the hammer tricks, they were good! But that was like the *opening* of a good juggling or throwing act. Yoitha should have begun juggling hammers or boomeranging them through the air or something!

What an odd act. What a disappointing performance.

Then came Rolaireness, and Seraphel began to realize the Synphasias might not be Cara's best career move after all.

The half-Elf was probably one of the more handsome ones that Seraphel had ever known, and they were, by and large, attractive. They were half-Elf. Half-immortal, and a mortal [Princess] on her best day would struggle to capture that timeless beauty they had innately.

But half-Elves were still a species, and they could vary in appearance. Rolare was the kind you looked for as a classic.

He was tall, had fair blond hair, and a kind of effortless poise to him. It wasn't that he took attentive care of his looks. Rather, he seemed to be like a wild traveller from stories, and his clothing matched.

She could literally see a patch on one elbow where a hand-sewn piece of dark red cloth interrupted the subtle greens and browns of his tunic and cloak. He wore handmade clothing, and yet the cloth seemed softer than any cotton she had ever seen.

Half-Elven garments. He must come from the timeless villages where they perfect anything and everything.

"Why does he look so beautiful?"

Thistel whispered, and Seraphel realized her [Handmaiden] had never seen a half-Elf like Rolare. She turned and whispered.

“He’s from a village, Thistel. Not like the half-Elves of Gaiil-Drome who come to the city and circulate. The villages where half-Elves pass years by without noticing it are far different from half-Elves in our world. Some of them will do the same thing, eat the same meal, for decades.”

“No wonder he’s not pressed for time.”

Dalimont nodded. Rolare had been brought out after Yoitha; the manager clearly sensed he was losing his audience, but the half-Elf just sat on a tall stool, tuning his violin.

He was tuning it, plucking at a string, drawing the bow of his violin over the string, and then he’d shake his head and go back to adjusting one of the knobs on the end. He would move the knob *ever-so-slightly*, just a touch sometimes, and then try again. Then he’d apply a bit of wax paper to the string, buff at an imperfection on the violin—and keep at it.

He *refused* to play. Even with thousands of eyes on him and King Itremeides making loud comments from the booth—the half-Elf just glanced up at the annoyed [King of Bows] and went back to tuning.

“Is he going to play or not?”

King Itreimedes called down after eight *minutes* of Rolare sitting and tuning his violin. Seraphel realized she had barely noticed time passing.

Oh, it was annoying to see the half-Elf sit there and occasionally tune a note. He was on the last string of his violin, and she really couldn’t tell the difference between his micro-adjustments. And yet—there was also something oddly hypnotic about how methodical he was.

As if he had forever to find that perfect note. However, at Itreimedes’ loud question, a susurrations arose from the audience. Rolare raised his head and spoke.

“I will play if I am ready. I am not. If you interrupt me, I will not play at all.”

The audacity! Even Avel’s laid-back court was aghast, and the [Manager] practically sprinted out to apologize and send Rolare backstage. The half-Elf got up and walked behind the curtains, still tuning his violin.

Had he been doing that all this time? Seraphel bet he had, and she understood the audience’s discontent.

“The nerve of that man, speaking to a [King] that way! Even if he is a half-Elf! Can’t he play with that violin? I’ve heard countless performers, and his violin *is* tuned!”

Mariel was outraged. The [Maid] was also correct, but Dalimont leaned over and murmured.

“I think he can tell the difference, Mariel. No wonder the Synphasias has such issues. I don’t doubt this Rolare is a genius with the violin, but he’s a timeless half-Elf. He won’t play unless the conditions are perfect—and they’re likely not to be, since he’s left his village.”

“Is he *that* good?”

Itremeides had heard Dalimont, and the [King] was visibly annoyed at being lectured. Dalimont bowed to the [King] as the stage lay empty and the [Manager] was clearly running around trying to find another act.

“Your Majesty, have you heard the tale of the blademaker without peer?”

“Oh, that. Yes, I see your point. But what an unctuous fellow.”

The [King] rolled his eyes, and Seraphel sat up.

“What blademaker? I don’t know the story, Dalimont. Tell it to me.”

The [Knight] glanced down, but there was no one on stage, and he realized even the audience below was listening because this was more entertaining

than the performance so far. Seraphel just bet a number were going to demand their two-thirds refund after this.

Dalimont cleared his throat. Somewhat embarrassed, he spoke to Seraphel.

“It’s a simple story that explains half-Elves to those who have never met one from a village, Your Highness. They do the same thing, every day, and find enjoyment in acts as simple as tending to beehives, growing flowers, and so on. They can live a century or more like this, and to them, that isn’t a full lifetime. They are not always idle, either. Half-Elves still love to refine their goods, so a bottle of wine from a true half-Elven village is considered the rarest and most decadent thing in the world.”

Seraphel knew that. Dalimont went on, speaking louder; Seraphel thought she could hear the manager shouting backstage behind the curtain.

“—Well, there is a famous tale of a half-Elf who studied the blade in a village. Once, a band of famous adventurers, Named-ranks, came across his village and saw he was practicing with the blade. He had such perfect form that they challenged him to show them his Skills. He did—and before any of them could so much as touch him, he had a blade at their throat. He could slash through steel, move faster than even their own [Blademaster]... and he won eight duels in a row with a single move.”

Impressive, if true. Itreimedes was nodding along, and Seraphel bet it was a popular story among a certain martial mindset. She wondered if her brothers, the [Princes], knew this story. Probably.

“And so he humiliated the Named-ranks?”

Dalimont shook his head.

“Almost. After his eighth loss, the [Blademaster] swore he had to win *once!* So he managed to deflect the half-Elf’s first strike on the ninth duel. Whereupon the half-Elf put down his sword and announced he had lost. He was quite upset and went back to training without a word.”

“...Why? Because he bet it all on one strike?”

The [Knight] shook his head.

“No. The adventurers demanded he continue the match, but the half-Elf claimed he’d lost when his first move failed. You see—when the [Blademaster] demanded he continue fighting, begged to learn from the half-Elf, the immortal blademaster claimed he had nothing to teach. *Only the first strike*. He said he had never practiced a second one. To him, it was simply a hobby.”

“So he mastered one blow? That’s silly.”

Thistel remarked with a laugh, and Dalimont smiled ruefully.

“That’s how they think, Miss Thistel. It’s a famous little story, but the half-Elves rather dislike it. I—oh. It seems the performance is back. Apologies, Your Highness.”

He sat back, and the manager returned. Now, the man’s makeup was running and he was sweating, but he beamed and shouted up.

“Esteemed guests, Your Majesties—*my deepest apologies*. Rolare will continue to prepare for his performance. In—in the meantime, we have one final act! A new performer has come to the Synphasia! I present to you the songs of Cara, a singer and dancer! She’s no ordinary musician, though. Why—she’s the Siren of Songs, the Duchess of Dancing! *Cara O’ Sullivan!*”

Then he dashed offstage, and Seraphel began laughing. The discontented audience was not happy, and it seemed like the last performer of the theatre was being tossed to the wolves.

“Siren of Songs? I’ve heard of the Siren of Savere, but that’s a name.”

Itreimedes was leaning back in his chair, hands behind his head, clearly fed-up and regretting coming here. He didn’t even look up as a young woman strode onto the stage. Seraphel *swore* she saw Cara lower a middle finger—and she sat up.

“She’s dyed her hair. Look! It’s pink!”

Cara wore a bright outfit like the other performers, and her hair was indeed a shocking *pink*. She was scowling—for half a second before she smiled, and only Seraphel saw how mad she had been.

“Ladies and gentlemen, I am Cara, a [Singer]! I hope you enjoy my humble performance. I apologize for the interruptions tonight.”

She was projecting her voice into the edges of the theater, and Seraphel’s heart leapt as she saw her friend. Cara, that mysterious girl who didn’t *fit*—made some of the audience pause and look up.

Few of the other performers had said anything, just launched into their acts. It was the job of the manager to call them out.

But the night was a bad one, and several members of the audience were getting up and just walking out of the theatre, looking discontent. They clearly thought Rolare wasn’t going to perform, and the last act wasn’t one they were sticking around for.

To be fair, that was because it was very clear Cara wasn’t ready. Her colorful costume was only a jacket, and she had her worn travelling pants on—‘jeans’, she’d called them.

Seraphel’s heart sank when she noticed that. Had she made Cara come on stage early? No—the [Manager] had clearly run out of options. Cara was standing there, and her eyes flicked up. She met Seraphel’s gaze, and the [Princess] knew that Cara wasn’t ready.

But that had never stopped her before. Cara cleared her voice, and her eyes slid left, off-stage.

“I regret that my music isn’t ready. Give me just five minutes, and it will be ready. Again, I apologize for—”

It wasn’t even ready? The audience that had been wavering began to get up. They were fed up—and even King Itreimedes was shaking his head.

“What a waste of time. Gaah! Who suggested this? It’s definitely a *curse*—don’t kick me!”

Seraphel ignored him. She was holding her hands together, squeezing them as she looked down at Cara. The [Singer] was watching the audience leave, and she looked around—then her eyes flicked up.

Cara didn’t have to be here. She could have just refused to come out or let the blame fall on Rolare, the central act, or that idiotic manager. But she took a bow solemnly.

“I apologize, ladies and gentlemen. One minute. It’s almost ready.”

There was a strange sound coming from the side. It sounded...like an odd melody of flutes for a second. Seraphel craned her head as the noise cut off.

She’d never heard something like that. It sounded like an entire plethora of instruments starting—then falling silent. Did Cara have an entire orchestra hidden off-stage?

Some members of the audience looked back at Cara and wavered, but there was a trend towards the doors, and more people were joining in the simple pressure to leave. The King of Avel was going—and Cara’s eyes were fixed on Seraphel’s.

They were pleading. She was asking...something. What? Seraphel didn’t know, but she half-rose. Heart pounding. Did Cara need help?

She had never asked for it. Seraphel hesitated—then she did the most [Princess]-like thing she could imagine.

She started applauding.

A lone [Princess] began to applaud from the royal booth in the Synphasia. Seemingly oblivious to how silly she looked, Seraphel clapped her hands together like royalty. That genteel slapping of hands that didn’t make much sound.

But the audience looked up and heard the faint sound. Cara stared at Seraphel—and the applause was joined by the ringing of metal.

Ser Dalimont stared at Seraphel—then Cara—then leapt to his feet. He began to applaud, and the other Thronebearers joined him in a second.

Mariel and Thistel looked at Seraphel and the [Knights] as if they were mad—but Dalimont hissed at them.

“Applaud! Eternal Throne—applaud!”

The two [Maids] joined in, and King Ireimedes turned. He stared at Seraphel as if she were a loon, but he hesitated. So did the audience. They turned—and several people saw the [Princess] applauding the young woman on stage.

So they joined in with the vague sense that if they didn’t it would make them look boorish. The applause grew, and Seraphel felt a flush on her cheeks as everyone looked at her. Ireimedes was certainly giving her a look as if she were as stupid as could be.

But Cara’s nervous breathing calmed. She looked up at Seraphel, and this time—when she bowed—it was to Seraphel alone. Then—she raised her head, cupped her hands to her mouth, and called out.

“Your Highness, we meet again!”

Even the people who’d stepped into the lobby poked their heads back in at this. The young woman shouted up at Seraphel, and Avel’s court murmured. But Cara was smiling now, and she shouted at Seraphel.

“I thought I wouldn’t see you for ages. Thank you for visiting my humble performance. I apologize for it all—but that you stayed—this song will be for you, Your Highness, Seraphel!”

The 4th Princess of Calanfer knew this [Singer]? More than one person went back to their seats. Even if this was terrible, it was still interesting because of that. The outwards flow reversed—and Seraphel smiled at Cara.

She had bought the time Cara needed. The [Singer] paused as people trickled back to their seats. She was glancing left, raising a thumb, waiting for a signal off-stage.

The King of Bows had gotten tired of standing and had flopped back into his seat. He was in a bad mood, skeptical—and Cara had only one chance. She was at the tail end of a bad performance, but she still stood there.

“One song. I apologize that I can’t do more—but for the [Princess] of Calanfer, for strange meetings—I have been thinking of you, Your Highness. I wish we had talked longer. I’m happy to see you.”

She made Seraphel’s heart warm. Cara looked up at her, and it seemed to the uncomfortable audience as if the two were speaking just together. Then...they realized a faint sound was playing. A strange, stringed instrument. Deeper than any harp that Seraphel had ever known, and light, ethereal sounds.

A deep, resonant drum. And still, Cara was speaking.

“I’ve made a lot of mistakes. I know I haven’t been perfect—but give it some time. There’s not a single day goes by where you don’t cross my mind.”

Me? Seraphel blinked—and then she realized Cara’s voice was pitched. The music was playing louder, and the audience realized Cara was singing.

She transitioned into the song so smoothly that it seemed she was just continuing speaking at first. Then—it was clear she was singing. She turned, threw her head back, and pointed to Seraphel.

She closed her eyes, put a hand over her heart, and began to sing. Her face changed as if she were mourning. Pained.

“All the days spent on my mind. All the times that I’d say that we’ll be together, we’ll be together, oh. All the ways to see through my heart. I know the good intentions, they won’t be lost forever, won’t be lost forever, oh—”

It was a love song! Or—close enough! Seraphel realized what the lyrics sounded like and turned red! Dalimont choked—and Cara’s eyes opened wide. She gave Seraphel a mischievous smile—then twirled around. When she whirled back, she pointed at her next target.

“Oh, but not a single day goes by where you don’t cross my mind. Not a single day goes by where you don’t cross my mind. Not a single day goes by where you don’t cross my mind!”

She looked at Ser Dalimont, and King Itreimedes turned his head as if suspecting the [Knight] and Cara...the [Singer] trailed down the stage, looking at members of the audience. And they were listening.

What style was this song? It was fast and slow to Seraphel. The music was strange, and it had horns and unnaturally high pitches she doubted any horn could emulate. Like all of Cara’s music, it was new.

It captured the audience. A love-song, a song between friends. Sad and hopeful.

An apology from a [Singer] who met Seraphel’s eyes, and the two had missed each other. It hadn’t even been that long. But when Seraphel saw Cara standing there—

She started smiling. Cara sang. It wasn’t even a long song, barely three and a half minutes. But of all the performances in the Synphasia—it alone felt so new and fresh and welcome. Unlike the bored, generic acts trying to capture a bit of attention, the uncertain Dwarf trying to be unique—

Cara just sang a song. But she stood on that stage as if it belonged to her and with the confidence to sing one song and capture everyone. A performer in her very bones.

The [Singer].

When she finished, there was a long silence. Then—the applause began before Seraphel even brought her hands together.

They didn't knock down the theatre with cheers. There were no brocades of flowers being tossed on stage—but King Itreimedes brought his hands together, slightly mollified. Cara bowed once, and Seraphel was smiling.

It didn't make up for the rest, but the audience had taken Cara's side. She was glancing to the side.

"Thank you, ladies and gentlemen. That was—'Cross My Mind'. A song for someone I've had the honor of knowing. I can continue. The next song, for travellers near and far, is 'Oceans Away'."

She seemed to be saying that very carefully, and the audience leaned forwards, relieved she wasn't done with one song. She was doing it! Seraphel smiled—

Until the curtains opened, and the [Manager] strode out. He grabbed Cara's arm and began to tow her off-stage.

"Huh? What's going—"

Itreimedes groaned as Cara jerked and tried to stay—but was pushed behind the curtain. The dismayed audience heard her arguing, then they began to get mad. Seraphel half-rose.

"What's going on? She was doing well! What—"

Rolare the Violinist stepped back onto stage. This time, *Seraphel* nearly hurled something down at him. The half-Elf's chin was raised, and he actually rubbed at his ear as he had found Cara's song odious.

"Oh dead gods, not him again."

Itreimedes got up, glaring. The audience muttered loudly—and Rolare lifted a hand. He had his violin resting against his chin, and he raised the bow. King Itreimedes slowly raised *his* bow as one of his advisors tried to snatch an arrow from his grip. The Noelictus audience was tellingly silent, and Seraphel was glaring. The half-Elf ignored them all and closed his eyes.

Then he put the bow to the string and began to play. Seraphel, despite her love of her friend, despite her annoyance at the performances—forgot she was going to be married. She forgot the chair she was sitting in was slightly too large for her.

She forgot the stickiness on her hands from the King of Avel's grip. She forgot her worries, what she was meant to do next. She saw Rolare touch the bow of his violin to the strings—

And he played music that she had never heard an equal to. Not from Barelle, not in all her days in Calanfer's courts. It began slow, a lilting tone as if the half-Elf were sitting by himself, in a world where the world began and ended in a space around him.

Then it grew, and he played faster, a solo act that somehow sounded like a quartet. He played as if the violin were just a vessel and he was the conduit to music that transcended his instrument.

A single song that he had spent decades learning. An immortal's music, perfect in every note. And for eight minutes, Seraphel forgot she had been sad. She forgot the dead, her mistakes, and the future.

She listened—and from the moment the half-Elf began until he lowered his bow and stood—she was spellbound. When he finished, she got up and applauded. And she was ashamed that it took her nearly half an hour to even remember Cara's song thereafter. The audience flooded out the theatre, talking quietly, queuing to meet the haughty half-Elf and the other performers looking ashamed or trying to be remembered.

So that was the Synphasia Theatre and its performers. Errors, spectacle, talent clashing with ineptitude, an unctuous manager, and...

Seraphel saw Cara standing there, arms crossed, but unable to say anything to the half-Elf who stood there, taking it all as his due. And Seraphel realized her friend might be happy here.

She had competition.

Cara actually spoke to Seraphel only three hours later when the [Princess] had retired to her mansion. Seraphel heard a commotion at the door and found Cara gulping down the leftovers from her dinner.

“Seraphel!”

“Cara! You were magnificent. Where have you been?”

Cara got up fast, and Seraphel embraced her. There was a moment of uncertainty when Seraphel wasn’t sure what to do, but Cara decided for her.

She looked—well. Less like someone who had walked through a literal war, as she had after surviving the [Necromancer] attack and rallying the ghosts. But she was hungry.

“I’m sorry. We don’t eat until we’re done, and that damned [Manager], Joeired is his name, was all over the [King] of Avel. He’s puffed up because the violinist finally did his job. It’s been two weeks, and that was the first time he’s played since I was accepted.”

“Really? So the odds he actually would have refused to play—”

Cara rolled her eyes as she shoveled black noodles into her mouth.

“High! He would have rather been fired, that prick, than be ‘forced’ to perform. A prima donna artist if there ever was one. I hate how good he is...but I think he went out there because I performed. He was complaining his string was slightly off afterwards and the entire thing was rubbish.”

“He thought he was *off*? You were splendid.”

Cara paused and gave Seraphel a familiar, wry, self-deprecating look. She shook her head slowly.

“I was alright. That was improv at its best. Thanks to you, we kept the audience in their seats, but I get it now. Rolare is a world apart. Gah. I always thought I could stand up and match someone if I ever met the ‘best’,

but I couldn't even say a word when he walked off stage. He did things with that violin that I don't think you could do back home!"

She was frustrated, admiring, and looked alive. Seraphel sat there as Dalimont cleared his throat.

"What Her Highness meant was—where have you been, Cara? We lost track of you for a month before coming to Menorome."

Cara blinked and smiled at him.

"Dalimont, are you spying on me?"

"Only casually, Miss Cara. How did you come to the City of Repose?"

The [Singer] sighed.

"Caravaning. I hired onto a team and learned how to repair axles and did that for a month. It was good. It let me figure things out. For one thing—I'm only good at music. I can hack it at another job for a while, but the stage is where I can stand out. Not everyone can be the real thing like Rolare. Seraphel, how's Culin? Sasi?"

She looked at the [Princess], and Seraphel explained they were well. She mentioned the ghosts, and Cara sat forwards.

"Arteis? I bet she's scary enough to keep half the dead away. And Dalius... is he well?"

"He's Culin's personal guard, and the boy can only sleep in his presence."

Cara smiled with a hint of pain behind her raised lips.

"That's good. He's—a good protector. I wish I'd stayed, sometimes. The rest of the time, I'm glad I left. I'm not fit company for them. Not right now."

She was the perfect company for Culin and Sasi. Or Seraphel. The [Princess] toyed with a saltshaker.

“—You’re a welcome sight in Menorome, Cara. Are you truly trying to become a top performer in the Synphasia?”

“Yes. I have to try. And with respect to your help—I want to do it on my own. Prove I can make something of myself. I’m levelling and working on songs and...once I’m ready, I’ll be able to return. When I know who I am. Does that make sense?”

Cara pushed her plate back, and Seraphel nodded slowly. Though she had never had the chance to do what Cara wanted. *She was due to be wed...*

“...How are you doing?”

Cara seemed to notice Seraphel’s reserve, and the [Princess] smiled gaily.

“Oh, just grand. My parents gave me this mansion, and Menorome is filled with delights. Why, they even sent me a handsome allowance, and I have been touring Menorome. I’m due to visit the palace in a few days.”

The [Singer] stared at Seraphel, then glanced at Dalimont.

“Are you keeping Seraphel here against her will? Can’t you let her run away or something?”

The [Knight] hesitated as Seraphel blinked at Cara.

“We must all do our duties, Miss Sullivan.”

“I guess if that helps you sleep at night...can I do anything for you, Seraphel?”

The [Princess] saw Cara glance around at the opulent mansion, and she wished the [Singer] had the power to annul the marriage or...

“If you would visit, I will happily have the [Chef] feed you, and I would love your company, Cara. I visit the palace in three days.”

“And I’m working the night shift. It’s *all* night-shift around here. But if you’re free...I’ll come by every day. My apartment is not so nice that I

want to use it. It's attached to the Synphasias Theatre and—well, let's just say that the building looks a lot worse behind the scenes. You know that Dwarf, Yoitha?"

"The...one who had such a unique performance?"

Cara smiled as Seraphel hesitated, and both laughed. But then she grew serious.

"No, she knows it's bad, but she's trying to stand out. The reason she even has an act is because she helps fix the theatre up free-of-charge. And she's a great person. She was the one who helped set up my music...speaking of which, um."

Cara was fidgeting, and the [Princess] realized she was nervous. Cara was already in a bit of trouble, or at least, intrigue, it seemed. She lowered her voice.

"...Do you know about a place called 'Wistram Academy' by any chance, Seraphel? Dalimont? The Academy of Mages? They have a Guild in this city and—"

Both Dalimont and Seraphel began laughing at once. Cara turned beet red.

"I know it's common knowledge! I meant, do you know anyone in—how trustworthy—argh!"

She betrayed herself. It was unintentional, but to Dalimont and Seraphel, trained disassemblers, asking about the most famous institution of magic in this world was just silly. Then Seraphel grew worried.

"Is Wistram Academy looking into you, Cara?"

"Someone is. I'm not sure whether to think they're trustworthy or what."

"Be careful. The Archmages are very powerful leaders. Wistram has more power than most nations—though it is entirely faction-based there. What is the matter, exactly?"

“...They want to know where I am. Well, they *know*, but someone’s giving me help, and he seems genuine, if a bit of an idiot. I’m taking his help...tell you what. Let’s talk about Wistram. You give me a history lesson, and I’ll, uh—”

“Give us a history lesson on something you know?”

Seraphel met Cara’s gaze, and the [Singer] exhaled. But before she could agree or disagree, Seraphel shook her head.

“I will tell you all you need to know, Cara. Forget about your story. Dalimont, find us some dessert. Perhaps some tea for Cara’s throat?”

The [Singer] eyed Seraphel with a hint of suspicion. But Seraphel was just smiling. She adjusted her skirts, and Cara exhaled.

“You’re not curious?”

“I think...it would matter greatly, and my mother and father would insist I drag everything out of you, Cara. But I am simply too happy to see you. Besides—it doesn’t matter.”

Seraphel stood and turned. She smiled fondly at her friend.

“I’m to be wed and my loyalties split between Calanfer and Noelictus. A good [Princess] would do all in her power. But I would rather be a better friend.”

Her head turned, and she looked at the rest of the staff, her maids, Mariel and Thistel, the Thronebearers, Dalimont, Dame Neranthei—

The female Thronebearer looked nervous, and Seraphel shot her entourage a warning look.

“Lest my people believe it would be better to report behind my back, I have long ears, and I am quite capable of making your lives miserable even with my royal parents’ protection. Your secrets are safe with me, Cara.”

Cara looked at Seraphel. Then she stood up and took a huge sip from the cup Dalimont handed her. She slung an arm around Seraphel and squeezed as the [Princess] started.

Mariel looked horrified by the too-familiar contact. But Cara just nodded at Seraphel.

“Let’s make the best of it. Say, you said you sang, Seraphel. You said you wanted to practice again. You could help me work on my songs. Just until weddings and all that.”

The [Princess] hesitated. Then she smiled. The [Princess] felt Menorome come alive again.

It was a strange, precious feeling for the first time in her life. A too-good ebullience that felt fake.

Was this what having a friend felt like?

She wondered why she had been missing it all her life.

[Widow Princess Level 19!]

[Skill – Voice: Perfect Pitch obtained!]

Digneral

Ailendamus was not a nation that made mistakes twice. Part of the reason why it had his loyalty was because he believed that his kingdom worked.

More than monetary rewards, prestige, or anything else was Digneral’s belief that Ailendamus was doing it better than other nations.

His education in the schools was proof of that. In addition, he was a [Baron], a noble of Ailendamus, but he was not above censure or the law.

The Court of Masks was an example of how Ailendamus ran. It was an egalitarian place where anyone could speak, from a servant to a noble, and

be judged only on the merits of their arguments. It was designed to let everyone wear a literal mask and speak without fear of censure.

Similarly, Ailendamus had judges, the venerable House Shoel, who executed the law in place of the nobility. They heard cases rather than Digneral being expected to lay down the law.

These systems created accountability and superior results. In the same way, Digneral's own warfront with Ovela was not one he was allowed to run as he pleased.

He was given broad power, soldiers, even [Knights], and he had his own demesne to draw upon for resources, but to obtain the crown's support, he had to prove he was achieving results. If he was failing, he had better adhere to advice. Nor were his successes and failures purely judged on that; factors outside his control were acceptable.

Not that Digneral du Ecte felt he'd failed. On the contrary, when the inspection came, it was sudden, unannounced, and arguably painted him in the best light.

"Baron! Forgive the intrusion, but an emissary from the capital has arrived!"

The man didn't turn his head. He just growled beneath his helmet as light flashed across it. The skies were dark, overcast—but the flaming spells were giving him plenty of light.

Noelictus was always night. In this cool fall, it should have been a perfectly grim painting. A graveyard of fallen leaves, black and white, the ideal place for undead to haunt.

...The flames made it look far more hellish. Fire, orange and red, fell left and right, shot from the wands and battlemages towards his people's ranks.

Flame. Ovela loved flame. It was good against undead, and it was the terror of the infantry. Flames bypassed armor, and it could burn men and women alive even if they were covered in plate armor.

It was how [Knights] had been kept back from Ovela time and time again. But it was also an antiquated weapon.

Everything about his opponents was. They moved in ranks, huge formations of their peasantry, [Soldiers] armed with bows and pikes, slowly advancing, pivoting, following columns of [Riders] into the fray.

He would admit they were good. Ovela's Twins shared control of their army. One was a master of slow defensive pushes. Lord Fallien came up with heavy, shielded infantry, and he had his famous Hammer of Ovela firing constantly.

Stakes of wood as large as a man hammered into the ground. A rain of stones came next, bouncing off shields, and Digneral heard screams as one struck flesh. He gritted his teeth as his Greatbows fired back.

The Greatbows of Ailendamus were their signature weapon. They fired 'Lance-Arrows'—arrows literally as large as a lance and that could tear apart enemy formations—from the huge, 'X'-shaped bows .

Greatbows were a signature weapon, akin to a faster ballista, that Ailendamus created. Few siege weapons of this nature existed in Terandria, and they could manufacture more. Comparatively, old nations like Noelictus could neither manufacture nor create new weapons.

They had no [Engineers], no knowledge of how to build, and relied on relics of the past. Digneral's problem was...

Their last relic was a titanous machine of death. They called it the 'Hammer of Ovela'. And it was nothing but a giant ballista that was six times as large as the biggest ballista that Digneral had ever seen.

It could launch a huge stake of wood into battle from miles away. In fact, it wasn't even *on* this battlefield but in Ovela's keep.

It was one reason why Ovela hadn't fallen after years of war. That damned weapon alone could keep his forces back, and try as he might, he couldn't destroy it. Even his [Saboteurs] reported the very wood was enchanted, and flames, blades, and counter-fire from his Greatbows had failed.

Lord Fallien relied on it too much, despite its clear strategic advantage. He moved slowly, trying to simply press Digneral back. His sister was far more mobile.

Piral came charging across on her destrier, black-tipped lances lowered as her forces charged again and again at any weak spot they found. They carried crossbows and would shower their foes from range if they didn't find a spot for their lances to strike home.

Digneral admired her more than Fallien. For all her brother's command of traditional warfare was impeccable, she had adopted a modern way of fighting that echoed most [Knight]-orders, but combined it with the fighting style of Noelictus' [Hunters]. If she had possessed anyone from the Hunter's Guild, he had no doubt she would have been a fearsome foe.

As it was, the two twins were able to magnify their army's strengths and essentially covered the other's weakness. Where Fallien was slow, Piral was fast. She would hit from the sides while he pressed you. When her advance faltered for lack of reinforcements, he had his forces pushing in, unable to be stopped.

They hated each other, or so Digneral understood. A twin's rivalry magnified by their personalities and vying to be named the [Earl] of Ovela over the other. But they fought him, a common enemy, like twin leopards.

Their fierceness, Ovela's war-strength as a province seasoned by conflicts, and even the Hammer of Ovela meant that no foe had ever taken this province. They, like their father, were Noelictus' blockade against any foe coming from the east.

...But they were losing. Digneral never turned his head from the battlefield as the [Messenger] spoke again.

“Baron, the emissary—”

“I heard. I have no time for them! *Forwards the shields!* Push back Fallien! Drell Knights, prepare for the strike!”

This was his eighty-ninth battle against Ovela. Eighty-nine battles. Six years. He could not always be on the offensive; troops needed to be replaced. Skirmishes were common. Pitched battles like these forced both sides to recuperate if they took enough losses.

He had attacked and sallied forth to defend against their assaults. Digneral had never passed this deadman’s land just outside of Noelictus’ borders. Each and every time...

“*The Hammer is firing!*”

Someone screamed, and Digneral roared.

“Shields!”

He put his up and actually *felt* an impact as a stray stone landed amidst his command. It barely made him rock as he sat on horseback; his animal made a startled sound, but he controlled it.

His shield, like his armor, was enchanted. His helmet, in fact, was reflecting the firelight. Digneral looked like he wore a mirror of polished silver. In fact, the [Knights] preparing to charge echoed him.

Drell Knights. They wore glass-armor, far thicker than any glass you could normally hope to make. The semi-translucent material was tougher than steel, if heavier, and they were the most heavily-armed Order of Ailendamus.

The Order of the Thirsting Veil used poison. The Order of the Hydra fought on foot and were made up of common folk; they fought at legion strength and were numerous, more than any other [Knight]-Order in the world.

But the Order of Drell were Digneral’s folk. He was an honorary member, and when they charged—

More fire. Ovela's twins loved it. They shot flames from their wands, and their [Mages] threw [Fireballs] that exploded and killed everything they hit. This tactic had humbled the Dawn Concordat, Pheislant, and every other foe.

...But Digneral had studied his foe. And when his infantry saw the magic incoming, they raised their shields and the mirror-shields, oval teardrops—

They reflected the magic straight back.

[Army: Spell Reflection Shields]. The [Baron of the Mirror Lands] smiled coldly as half the spells either washed over his troops, who ignored the flames, or bounced back. Little of it hit his opponents; it was hard to reflect a spell straight back at a foe.

But it meant he weathered the Twins' onslaught. The Hammer of Ovela fired again, and Digneral grimaced as more of his people went down. But then he saw his Drell Knights charge.

Fallien's forces and his were locked in combat in the infantry, and he saw crossbows firing on both sides. Noelictus and Ailendamus both used crossbows over bows; it was another factor that set them apart from other nations who claimed bows were superior.

However, his troops were rotating back fast as Fallien pushed forwards. He was waving his sword from the back, howling an advance. As Digneral saw his troops buckle first. As intended. They fell back without taking mortal wounds. He pointed a finger, exhorting his front line of footsoldiers.

“Rearguard, hold them!”

Another line of his troops smashed forwards, and Fallien's lines wavered. Ailendamus [Soldiers] armored head-to-toe in steel, almost like miniature [Knights], rammed their spears into a front line of Ovelian troops, who collapsed.

“*[Give Them No Inch]! [Regain Morale]—[Countercharge]!*”

Fallien rallied the wavering front and sent another rank of his troops at Digneral's. The [Baron] watched as his rearguard slowed and their spears withdrew.

“Crossbows—loose!”

They *snapped*, and Fallien's advance slowed—but picked up as Digneral's rearguard retreated. He was in full retreat now, and here came Piral.

She was swooping in to rout his forces. But she ran straight into his Drell Knights. The heavily-armored horsemen *collided* with his [Knights], and a terrible clash ensued.

More armored than Piral's troops or not—she was a high-level [Lady], and Digneral winced as he saw his [Knights] go down. One speared an Ovelian troop only for Piral to knock him flat. He surrendered as both sides burnt down—and fell away.

Almost completely equal. She'd gone toe-to-toe with his Drell Knights and held them down. True, he hadn't led the charge himself, but Piral was insanely dangerous! Plus, his [Knights] had yielded, and they were being dragged to Noelictus' lines.

Each one would fetch a hefty ransom, and the Twins were not so rich as to turn down the opportunity to ignore that. The [Knights] would keep their honor and dignity, but pay for that with gold aplenty.

Digneral thought it was an antiquated method of making war that favored the lives of [Knights] over commonfolk. But so long as it was practiced...

He would use it. He let the fighting go on for a few minutes more, then raised a hand.

“Fall back! Fall back in good order!”

Once again, he retreated. Ovela raised a huge cheer as his silent troops retreated, carrying hundreds of their wounded. Digneral snapped orders as he rode down the lines.

“[Healers], forwards! Break out the second set of healing potions!”

Healing potions, the miracle of magic, closed wounds and mended all but severed limbs. Dying [Soldiers] gasped and came back to life as he checked on his command.

His entire vanguard of infantry was wounded, having rotated in against Fallien’s hardened troops. Both sides had ground at each other hard—but he saw over ninety-eight percent of his people were alive.

Fallien had lost nearly nine percent if Digneral had calculated correctly. Not because his troops were notably lower-level—but Digneral prized heavy, Ailendamus armor for his soldiers. And Fallien didn’t rotate his frontline but pushed them into the enemy to force them to retreat.

Another loss. Digneral almost hummed, but didn’t out of respect for the dead. The Twins were *still* cheering, their supporters boasting who had done more. He had never met bigger fools, and only when he saw the emissary from the capital did Digneral feel a moment of fear.

Fear, because he wasn’t sure if the representative checking on him understood what he was doing or not. Not everyone would—but the pair of men simply nodded at him as he dismounted.

“Duke Rhisvseri! Viscount Visophecini! Your Grace, Viscount, I would have —”

“—Done nothing and continued to lead your forces if you knew it was us? I expect that was your reply, Baron Digneral.”

The sharp-tongued response came from the equally sharp-looking Duke. Rhisveri Zessoprical was brother to King Itorin II and one of the most powerful men in Ailendamus. He was a terrifyingly powerful spellcaster and had the [King]’s ear—and incredible authority over the military.

Too much, given the rumors Digneral had heard of him. He was a touchy man, as many powerful spellcasters were, and he had a sharp goatee. He was tall, commanding, and superior—there was no other word for it. He

looked down on everyone, including [Generals]. He was not a fond guest in the capital or at banquets, but that was just as well; he was rarely in attendance.

By contrast, Viscount Visophecine was a well-beloved figure everyone wished to see more of. He dressed in black, and his skin was the *faintest* bit grey. He had a curious cologne that smelled a bit like oil or sulfur, and his smile gave nothing away. He led House Shoel, who manufactured magical items and worked as judges of the realm. He was intelligent, able to dance, fight with the sword, talk politics, and entertain without fail, a man of many abilities.

Both were highly-placed and clearly here to observe Digneral's offensive. The [Baron] would have removed his helmet, but it was a stupid thing—he was more aghast neither had armor.

“Your Grace, we are close to the front. A [Sniper]—”

“—Would not penetrate my magical barriers. I assure you, Digneral, I will be the last man to die even if this entire army were torn to shreds. I am simply here to observe. Your apologies are unnecessary. We are here to assess your campaign against Ovela.”

He was grating, but Digneral just nodded. Visophecine gave him an apologetic nod and a half-smile.

“Forgive Duke Rhisveri's foul temper. He is often venomous, Baron Digneral. We are impressed by your performance.”

“It's adequate. Mind your tongue, Visophecine.”

For all he was rude, even to the Viscount, Rhisveri was intelligent. He flicked his eyes over the retreating Ailendamus forces.

“Do they often cheer, those Noelictus folk?”

“Ovela is a renowned province that celebrates its continued victories, Your Grace. Noisily.”

“Incredible. I truly thought they’d catch on, but I suppose the reports of those Twins didn’t exaggerate. They left twice our dead—or more!”

“Twice our dead in the ranks. Ranged fire was equalized by the Hammer of Ovela, but the Baron’s mirror-shields gave our [Mages] an overwhelming advantage. The Twins cannot be fools. How do they reconcile their losses?”

Visophecin observed. Both men were on foot, not horses, so Digneral left his mount to walk between them. They talked as his armies fell back to House Ecte lands.

“They raid into our borders and come away with gold. Artifacts—we do have artifacts Noelictus wants. Everything from purification stones in our wells to the mundane objects in our Mage’s Guilds. Even a Rune of Heating in a home is worth more gold than a [Soldier] of Ovela would see in half a year.”

“Incredible. So they trade gold for manpower. And they’ve been begging for more troops without the hindsight to keep theirs from dying?”

Rhisveri sneered at the distant Ovelian troops. Digneral had pulled back in very good order, and while they might claim any wounded on the battlefield—they would ransom them over killing them. Visophecin remarked calmly as he nodded back the way they’d come.

“Even if they understand what is going on, Baron Digneral has an advantage. His [Knights] are protected by the codes of war. He has reported less than a hundred Drell Knights falling in *six years* of fighting, Rhisveri.”

“Bah. We should have zero casualties if their armor was properly enchanted. In time, we will not need to bleed any foe. Aside from that relic from the Age of Blood—those Drell Knights should be able to take the entire field by themselves! That’s a goal for next century.”

Duke Rhisveri was an ambitious man. And a wise one. The Age of Blood? Digneral barely knew of that from old history books. And having their Drell Knights be nigh-immortal a century from now?

Visophecine flicked his gaze to Digneral. He glanced back at Ovela and then at House Ecte. As the weary Ailendamus troops marched back to their lands, the sky seemed to brighten and color return to the earth.

“How do the [Soldiers] maintain morale in what seems like an endless string of defeats, Baron?”

“We push back the Twins, and that is a victory. More than that? They are aware of the rough plan and generously compensated. I have, of course, told them nothing, but I think they can feel how weak Ovela has gotten. The Twins boast of their personal levels—but all of Earl Inameis’ old veterans are dead or retired. But for the Hammer of Ovela, they are down to [Battlemages] casting fire spells and low-level wands.”

Rhisveri could only shake his head several times.

“Idiots. So your soldiers...?”

“They sense a moment is coming to hammer Ovela. We have rotated eight fresh battalions into House Ecte. I will begin a fresh offensive in two days—and the Twins will have been expecting my forces to be consolidating their strength after their ‘loss’.”

Visophecine and Rhisveri exchanged a nod of great satisfaction. When Digneral had first proposed this ages ago, he’d had little support for the ambitious plan—until Duke Rhisveri had heard of it. Then he had personally forwarded Digneral’s ambitions, given him the supplies and manpower.

Now, Digneral felt Ovela was as weak as he needed it to be to put the final phase of his plan into action. The Twins treated their lands poorly; they demanded tributes of food or manpower from their counties and the capital, and they were too busy squabbling for power to realize Ailendamus had lost little.

Digneral now had more troops in his lands than Ovela had ever seen, and he was prepared to *push*. Push so hard that the Twins, who thought they had

been fighting him at full strength, would either crumble or demand aid from the capital. Either way—Digneral was ready to go the full mile.

“The Hammer of Ovela will be a problem. You have been reluctant to advance far into that hellscape. I will make arrangements for your infiltrators. Keep up the pressure, Baron. I have seen enough to satisfy me.”

Either he’d toured Digneral’s forces in private or he had really just wanted to see a battle. Either way, Digneral bowed, keeping his face straight as Rhisveri turned.

“Visophecín, coming?”

The other man shook his head.

“I shall keep the Baron company longer. After all, it would be good to get a measure of a man who might well become a Great General of Ailendamus.”

Great General. Digneral kept his face as straight as possible. There were only a handful of Ailendmaus’ greatest warleaders, along with their Great Knights. Rhisveri rolled his eyes.

“Oh, yes. If you succeed—if—Digneral, we will see more of you. Visophecín places such trust. I place mine in results. Speaking of which...is that Drell Knight everyone wants to become the next Great Knight around?”

He made a show of looking about, and Digneral bowed.

“Drell Knight Ouren is preparing for the actual advance, Your Grace. If you wish to see him spar...”

“Bah. No, I do not. He *may* serve if he hits Level 40. The Mirror Knight? Seems generic.”

He was terribly rude to a young man who had nearly hit Level 40, the territory of Named-rank adventurers. Even Digneral could not help but frown in reproof, but Rhisveri ignored it. He strode off the way he’d come, snarling that he didn’t need a horse and would get back on his own.

“Forgive Duke Rhisveri. I fear you may meet more of him if you rise in command...but we have great expectations for the Noelictus offensive. You will be needed once we try the Dawn Concordat next year.”

Visophecine murmured, and Digneral’s heart rate spiked. Ailendamus was preparing to sweep the board. Noelictus first...whether or not he took more than Ovela depended on how the capital reacted, but the loss of their frontline would put the Kingdom of Shades on the back foot. Next year—the southlands. He bowed slightly to Visophecine.

“If you would care to join me—I do not drink wine, but I will toast to our advance.”

The Viscount smiled politely.

“I do not care for purified water, but I will partake of some wine myself. Each to their own, Baron. I will not stay for the advance, but rest assured, Rhisveri and I wished to see the battle. After all, House Ecte neighbors the Fiter Forest, and it would not do to disturb the folk there.”

Digneral kept his face straight and blank. The odds of anyone bypassing House Ecte’s lines...perhaps that was an excuse for the two men to inspect his readiness.

“I shall ensure Ovela is fully in retreat.”

“Very good. Rhisveri does care for the forest. If a Magistrate Fithea comes your way, it will be purely to observe Noelictus’ lands. We may consider terraforming them or restoring the forests.”

Dead gods, they were expecting victory. Magistrate Fithea was in charge of all of Ailendamus’ forests and natural reserves. Digneral had never met her; there were countless officials, but the thought of injecting some life back into Ovela’s gloomy lands made him smile. He nodded.

“Just as you say. I shall host her every whim. Once I am done with the fighting. Let us find that wine for you, Viscount. Or would you allow me a first name basis?”

The man smiled.

“Visophecin will do, Digneral. I am not adverse to intimacy with those I respect. But have a care in the battles to come. Ailendamus needs men of your caliber.”

“I am but one of a company, with His Grace and yourself about.”

Digneral didn’t care for flattery, but he felt like some was called for after all this praise. Visophecin surprised him with his modesty as he lifted a hand and smiled, a sharp smile, like his teeth.

“Oh, Baron. We are hardly men like you at all. Hardly at your level or like you at all. Now, to our toast.”

Seraphel

Four days after meeting Cara again, Seraphel visited the palace.

To say she was nervous would be to overstate things. Seraphel was not tense; she had visited royal courts before, as she said.

But she grew tense the more she heard about the situation in Ovela. In fact, a [Message] arrived for her the very evening before her visit.

She was just smiling over Sasi and Culin thanking her for the treats, gushing about sharing them with everyone and how sad the ghosts were they couldn’t eat them when her father sent her a note. He was not often effusive or wrote like one would to other members of their family in private.

This came from a personal, encoded [Message] scroll that Dalimont himself had to decipher, and the [Knight] was thus grave when he showed Seraphel the contents of the missive. The [Princess] read it, and her heart sank.

Seraphel,

Ovela’s been pushed back by a crushing offensive from Baron Digneral of Ailendamus. Your husband—safe. His twin—safe. But it means the wedding

may be delayed again.

Your job in the court is to make His Majesty aware we are standing with Noelictus. Which means Noelictus must stand with Ovela and not drop them. Play into whatever he wants of you. He's already curious about Afiele. Make it clear that Ailendamus won't stop.

They sent the [Necromancer] after Afiele. Can't confirm it, but Ielane's [Informants] say that fellow was likely hired by Ailendamus. Be careful how you claim it, but push them to send whatever they can. [Hunters], troops, I know their Landsreight squabbles, but pull together as much support as you can. I'm counting on you to—

Seraphel stopped reading because the ringing in her ears had grown too loud. She put the letter down and stumbled back.

“They hired the [Necromancer]? *They hired him to—?*”

“Your Highness!”

Dalimont caught Seraphel as she actually came closer to fainting than she ever had in her life. When that passed—Seraphel was filled with a rage unlike anything she'd felt.

“They murdered so many innocent—how could they hire a [Necromancer]? After Az'kerash? Every nation in Terandria will condemn them!”

“I'm sure His Majesty is trying to obtain incontrovertible proof, Your Highness. It must be difficult, and an unfounded accusation would hurt the Eternal Throne greatly. Please, bear his missive in mind—”

“I shall! And what's this about not supporting Ovela? Afiele is one of the counties there! Culin and Sasi are in danger!”

“Not with the ghosts.”

Dame Neranthei assured Seraphel, and that was true, but a war? The children and the people had suffered too much! Seraphel paced around the room, then sat in a carriage as they tried to recalibrate her tasks.

“The problem is that the crown is unlikely to want to give too much to Ovela, Your Highness. No noble should wield too much power, and Ovela is said to have an army on par with the capital’s. Not that Noelictus is famous for its standing army.”

“Yet they should have *some* support, surely!”

Dalimont nodded.

“Of course, Your Highness. The question is—how much? If you have His Majesty’s ear over Afiele, you can do a good amount. The other problem is the Landsreight, their parliament of nobles. They are also self-interested and will object to the crown levying more taxes. A lot of gold goes into Menorome, and demanding more soldiers and arms from them...”

“Self-interested nobility. I see. Who am I convincing?”

Seraphel was more motivated than usual, so she listened as Dalimont rattled out names.

“Mostly the provincial nobles. The province of Havens has Marquis Seelthru, who is largely self-absorbed. Unlikely to do anything unless he receives more tax exemptions from the crown. The province of Fiskren... *Duke* Fiskren, so it’s a family that hasn’t changed since the province was founded. He’s very dutiful, so you’ll likely have his attention especially since his daughter is a famous adventurer. Duchess Greina.”

“Oh, the third most eligible bachelorette of Terandria. Isn’t she a stellar warrior?”

Seraphel gloomed over slightly at the thought of meeting Greina, a rising star. It wasn’t that she felt jealous—but it hurt to see someone so beloved and popular—*and high-level*.

Dame Neranthei spoke with the enthusiasm that said she was a fan of Greina’s.

“She’s a former [Hunter] of Noelictus. A crack-shot with her crossbow *and* an aura-master, Your Highness. You have aura training, don’t you?”

“Yes, and mine’s as weak as spit, Neranthei. Very well, very *well*.”

Seraphel reminded herself that she was Level 19, a full three levels higher than she had been earlier this year. Even if her Skills weren’t that amazing...she sat up a bit as Dalimont gave her an encouraging look.

“Besides that, there’s the Hunter’s Guild as the third major power. Huntress Agshiga commands the Deathhunt—that’s their elite undead-slaying unit. They stay out of wars, but if you meet a Guildmistress Deilfec, they may be inclined to provide arms or something. They may also be the largest objectors to Ovelian aid.”

“...Why?”

“Because the Hunter’s Guild receives a large share of the crown’s finances. To quell undead. And for the Hunter’s Cards.”

Seraphel vaguely remembered seeing [Hunters] in Noelictus. She bit her lip.

“Was that the fellow who rented out half a restaurant and ate his weight in pasta?”

“That was a [Hunter], Your Highness.”

“He weighed more than Dalimont in armor! And he flashed a card and it was all paid for! He must have eaten at least...ten gold’s worth of food! That is a lot, right?”

Thistel gave her employer a pained look, and Seraphel exhaled.

“Okay, it is a lot! He can damn well tighten his belt then. I understand what must be done. Beautiful first impressions. Er—is this gown really fitting?”

She eyed her dress, which was a somber ghost-white, the color of death. She felt like she was going to a funeral, and every time the folds of the

dress moved, they showed the black cloth underneath. She was a black-and-white flower...it was a gossamer thin white layer and beautiful in some ways, but two colors?

No Calanferian court would admire that. Ser Dalimont fussed with a little flower he took from a glass case. It was sunburst yellow, and he let Thistel pin it to Seraphel's front.

"Believe me, Your Highness, this is enough. Combined with your red hair, you'll be a splash in the courts as we understand it. Just remember—*good first impressions*. Play to King Allorev's whims, and please—"

"No sharp tongue. Believe me, I'll be a perfect [Princess] of Calanfer."

Seraphel assured Dalimont with a smile. And she meant it. She headed to the palace, and all went well...right up until she met the royal family.

Then the worst royal appearance in Seraphel's life began. And it was only partly her fault.

Honestly.

She did her best. But in all the little notes about people to meet, important levers to pull, and what to say and not say—the thing King Reclis seemed to have forgotten was the most obvious. And it was how *strange* the royal family really was.

The palace of Noelictus was called the 'Palace of Shadows'. It had been rebuilt long ago, after the Creler Wars that had devastated so much of the world. Entire kingdoms had gone down screaming, devoured by the horrors of Rhir.

Knight-Orders had vanished, and the world had been a step from being engulfed before they were pushed back and slain. In fact, Calanfer had been *founded* then, by the heroism of Queen Marquin the Radiant, who had helped push Crelers back.

So it was no small wonder the palace had been redesigned after that horrific day. The question Seraphel had as she rolled into the palace and first witnessed it up close was—

Who had a fetish for black on shadow, and why had they been given an unlimited budget?

Truly and seriously. Calanfer was often said to be a vision of the dawn, a shining land, and the Eternal Throne was literally a glowing sun of light—but even they knew the benefits of subtlety.

The palace was subtlety without any end. Seraphel tripped the moment she got out of the coach. Because the flagstones were black.

Not ‘black checkerwork’ or ‘midnight marble’ or even straight obsidian.

Darkness. She couldn’t see anything on the ground. In fact, when Thistel rushed forwards to pick Seraphel up, some pebbles from the city flew from the bottom of her shoes, and they stood out, tiny grey pebbles amidst a sea without form or end.

Not even the moonlight reflected from the ground.

“Dead gods. What a sight to see. What material is it?”

Dame Neranthei whispered loudly and forgot herself, because even a whisper was loud in this place of Noelictus. She turned, flinching, and the servants and bowing guards were standing there as Seraphel caught herself.

They, too, wore black-and-white cloth, but they stood out because the ones nearest Seraphel had what she took for fanciful shawls at first. It was only when she drew closer and Thistel clapped a hand over her mouth that she realized with a chill what it was.

Not veils or shawls. Instead—they were covered in spiderwebs. A [Servant] with a strange, black buttercup hat had a series of webs running down across her dress.

She bowed—and when she raised her head, Seraphel saw her dress was also made of cobwebs, as if a spider had woven the cloth. Was it actual thread of gossamer-thin webbing?

It looked like the latter. Seraphel expected a spider to crawl out from under the woman's hat any moment and her eyes, when Seraphel saw them, were even oddly striated, the irises more like spider webbing rather than normal.

A trio of [Servants] adorned like her bowed—then a *tall* figure wearing a mask like a crow removed it and spoke. A noblewoman's attire, but her dress billowed where it met the ground. She wore a shadow for a dress, and unlike the [Servants], her eyes were direct and had huge pupils. Her voice was a piercing whisper.

“Your Highness of Calanfer. Welcome to the Palace of Shadows. His Majesty awaits you. Mind your step. I am [Keeper of the Royal House], Liletrec. Your [Knights] of the Order of Thronebearer shine bright. Like golden stars, reflecting light.”

“Oh, thank you, Keeper Liletrec.”

Seraphel was completely taken aback by the odd servants. And therein made her first mistake. Because unlike the [Majordomo] of Calanfer or another servant—Liletrec's sharp expression, much like an owl or the crow's mask she wore, was not approving.

Nor was her tone.

“‘Twas no compliment. They may set His Majesty's dear friends to chattering. The royal court has no need of sun. Nor is the Queen in the mood for golden flowers of any kind.”

Ser Dalimont, Dame Neranthei, and the other [Knights] stiffened at the clear rebuke to Seraphel. But a [Royal Keeper] was highly-placed, so Dalimont bowed.

“I am Ser Dalimont, commander of the 4th Princess' royal bodyguard, Keeper Liletrec. May we oblige the crown in any way?”

“Removing your armor may suit. But something tells us a [Knight] will not accede.”

“That would be—difficult. I am bound not to remove my armor or abandon my [Princess]’ side in any way.”

The whispering [Keeper] replaced her mask as Dalimont admitted that slowly. Liletrec nodded, and then she *did* look like a great bird, standing there.

Only then did she *straighten*, and Seraphel realized she had to be seven feet tall! Did she have half-Giant blood or something? She loomed, and the [Princess] felt Mariel and Thistel hide behind her subtly. The curved beak and the two pupils visible through her mask were definitely scary.

Seraphel had to assume this was a mistake and this was, uh...the fashion of today? Royal dress had ridiculous trends. L-like lace. Lace was *all over* Calanfer, and it looked stupid.

“Keeper Liletrec, I apologize for any offense my [Knights] may make. I assure you, it was not intentional.”

“Ah, but it is done. So apologies do naught. Welcome, then, to the palace, bright [Princess]. His Majesty awaits you. Come at your leisure; the Court of Dusk awaits you.”

She gestured with one long arm, and Seraphel turned her head towards the open palace. Another odd way of saying things. What about the escort? Dalimont coughed uncertainly.

“Could we—perchance have a guide, Keeper?”

“As you choose.”

The woman spoke without moving visibly behind the mask. She pointed, and a [Maid] wearing cobwebs stepped forwards and bowed.

The webbing made Seraphel shudder, and Liletrec noticed.

“You are unnerved by our garb and the style of Noelictus, Your Highness.”

She said it like a fact, and Seraphel cursed inwardly. She gave the woman her best [False Smile].

“Not at all! I am delighted by Menorome’s grand spectacles, and I am merely—unaccustomed to the grand Palace of Shadows, Keeper.”

She thought it was a good excuse, and even if it was a lie, in any other nation—

“Liar.”

The [Keeper]’s voice was like a dagger that slashed through any niceties. Seraphel froze. This was *completely* out of her experience! The woman stood tall as Dalimont raised his voice.

“Keeper, with due respect—”

He was going to try to tactfully upbraid her; Calanfer had to save face. But again—the Keeper was operating completely differently to him. She swung her head around unnaturally, twisting her head without her torso.

“Respect? Respect is not something practiced in the Palace of Shadows, Ser Knight. Better if the [Princess] were honest. We have great expectations for the Cursed Princess of Calanfer and her famous ways.”

“I object, Keeper!”

Seraphel felt woozy at the direct reference to her nickname. That *was* an insult, and Dalimont put his hand on his sword. But Liletrec just *tsked* loudly.

“Perhaps we were mistaken. Thronebearers do poorly here for such famous diplomats. As for you, [Princess], your time in the courts may be unpleasant. Perhaps His Majesty will have a poor time of it. It shall be. I shall see you later, or not. Fare thee well.”

Then she spread her arms like two huge wings, the shadows billowed around her—and she *leapt* into the air. Seraphel’s mouth dropped.

She flew onto a balcony on the second floor! Landed—turned her masked head once, then stalked inside. Seraphel gobbled at her escort. They gobbled right back.

Dalimont’s mouth was hanging open. Then he jerked his attention to the [Guards]. They stood upright, men and women dressed in either perfect white or perfect black.

The ones wearing white were armed with bows. The ones in black, blades. They regarded the Calanferian delegation openly. The only one that moved, though, was the [Maid]. She folded her hands.

“To the Court of Dusk? Or elsewhere, Your Highness?”

“Where would I go but there? Thank you.”

Seraphel meant it as a rhetorical question, but the [Maid] halted and turned her spiderweb hat.

“Why, if you wish anywhere else, we will take you. Save the Queen’s domain.”

“I have an appointment with His Majesty, though.”

Not right away, but who would keep the sovereign [King] waiting? The [Maid] just shrugged.

“Doubtless it matters. The Court of Dusk has entertainments indeed as you wait. If you want for company...most new lords and ladies of Noelictus all make the same mistake.”

Mistake? Seraphel turned to look at Dalimont, but he had never experienced anything like this. That was her first opening to the courts of Menorome. Seraphel passed into that dark palace and realized they were either perfect cleaners or terrible.

The first hallway was *black*, just like the courtyard. So much so that any tiny stain would be obvious. She couldn't see the walls or ceiling or floor! She tripped twice—then passed into the rest of the Palace of Shadows.

Then she realized the King of Hosts, Allore, was perhaps a genial and welcoming [King]. But normal he was not.

Her one relief was that newcomers, and even regular nobles who attended the capital city of Menorome, looked as out-of-place as she did. They hung together near the buffet tables, and at least that was similar.

Royal courts had themes. Some were delicate affairs that moved from space to space, pursuing games and activities and following a royal member or occupying themselves. A constant stew of deals, gossip, and back-stabbery.

Others were more of a wide, open vista where you gathered in view of the throne. This was one of those styles, and Avel had a similar method, even if their [King] was less austere and often didn't sit on the throne itself.

In fact, King Ireimedes was here, probably to greet King Allore, and raiding the banquet tables. Those, too, were common. Everyone needed something to eat, and Seraphel saw there were lots of local Menorome treats in the vein of the stuff she had sent to Sasi and Culin.

White and black and grey in between. It made her feel like she was in a place someone had sucked the color out of. The floor itself was checkered, almost like a chessboard in the center, and so it almost seemed like the people were chess pieces as they mingled, an effect they clearly didn't enjoy.

That...was the most normal thing that Seraphel could imagine describing to her family and having them understand. Because if she talked about the rest of King Allore's Court of Dusk, no one would believe her.

Even with eccentrics like the Bedtime Queen and her literal bed she liked to sleep and work from or the Kingdom of Golaeron and the folk who had

descended from Giants who could be ten feet tall and lived in a vast kingdom that had once held Giants themselves—

Noelictus stood out.

The servants dressed like cobwebs figures, half of them. The other half wore masks over black and white outfits. Seraphel had heard there was a Court of Masks in Ailendamus and that they had taken inspiration from Noelictus' styles.

But where they wore masks in Ailendamus in one place—the servants here wore them as just natural costumes.

The Keeper's crow-mask was joined by an eerie, smiling mask. Another had a weeping, sad one, and their face was obscured but for that. They dressed in shadowy clothing that Dalimont finally identified.

“Shadowcloth.”

“Oh, how *wonderfully* descriptive. Where did you pull that name from, Dalimont? Your posterior?”

Seraphel was already on edge—she couldn't help but keep staring *up*. This couldn't be real. Dalimont spoke back as politely as he could.

“It's real, an ancient cloth that [Rogues] used back when the material could be made. I recall now—the staff uses clothing worn generations upon generations ago. But it does wear out, so the ones in the current garb...”

Seraphel got it. It was a neat trick to mix the ancient wear with the current style. And yes, spiderwebs befit the King of Hosts, Allorev.

Why?

Well—in the image that Seraphel would paint of the throne room and Court of Dusk, she would tell her sisters that it had some of the highest ceilings she'd ever seen. The Eternal Throne itself didn't count, but these had two hundred feet high ceilings and multiple floors that people could climb to look out onto the throne.

It sat far, far at the back of the rooms, and two staircases led to what Seraphel understood was the royal section of the palace, barred for most. Tall, silent bodyguards stood there, each one wearing a mask and Liletrec's style of dress.

Although in their case, they were armed with long, curious spears. More like a single piece of metal, tipped at one end, rather than the blade of a spear.

Spear-swords? Seraphel was no weapons expert, but Neranthei and Dalimont had clearly never seen such weapons before.

“Those must be the royal bodyguards. Ser Dalimont—have you ever heard of their prowess?”

“I have never seen them fight. Nor do they leave the throne room, by all accounts.”

“H-h-h-h-how are you not screaming?”

At this point, poor Mariel nearly screamed out loud. She was frozen in horror, and indeed, a number of new guests to the throne room...Seraphel... and even many of the nobility were not exactly admiring the bodyguards. Or the food. Or even the man who sat laughing on his throne, his red hair catching the candlelight.

Most of the people here were...staring up. At the spiders.

It was not a motif to look good. It was not a passing interest of the [King].

King Alloreve, the King of Hosts, was a somewhat famous name in Seraphel's history books because he was a [Prince] of Kaaz, that famous kingdom of haughty duelists and adventurers, one of the Sleeping Three to the north, the most powerful kingdoms in Terandria.

He had been, in his time, *the* [Prince] who flirted and won the hearts of countless women until he married into Noelictus. They called him his

nickname because he was charming, beloved—and had once been able to steal hearts like the current Lord of the Dance and other eligible men.

King of Hosts. King of parties. King of love, if you wanted to reduce his reputation to the simplest terms. But that heartstealer had come to Noelictus and had learned to steal a different kind of heart.

“Itreimedes, you rogue! Come here and stop stealing my favorite cakes! Bring your court—you bored man! Welcome to Menorome once more! My kingdom is open to Avel’s greatest bowman!”

“That’s Archer King to you, Allore!”

Itreimedes spun, and Seraphel heard a laugh from the figure on the throne. Allore stood, and his skin was duskier than most Terandrian’s. Yet he had the red hair that was proof of royal bloodlines, and when his gaze roamed the court—

Oh yes, she could see why he had been called the Prince of Hosts. Now there was a handsome man. But her admiration of his physical appearance lasted about half a second. Because Allore glanced at her.

“And Your Highness of Calanfer! *Welcome*. I hope Keeper Liletrec has not dismayed you? Gracious Calanfer is often at odds with Noelictus. We are a pit of sniping, snide, and petty folk. Dawn comes into our poor shadowed halls and reminds us of gentility.”

He was self-deprecating, eloquent, and made Seraphel blush and bow. She didn’t try to call back, and he simply lifted a hand. He was actually performing the role of a [Royal Caller]!

“We shall speak soon. Itreimedes, don’t mind my little friends. You would think you were used to them, so often do you visit. They’re simply agitated because of Calanfer’s golden sun. *Toxivichere*, what are you chittering for?”

Then he turned—and the hanging spider—about, oh, *fourteen feet long*—stopped rubbing its legs together. Seraphel had not stopped staring at it. She

had frozen the moment she stepped foot into Allore's throne room, looked up, and seen—

The spiders. They were all over the ceiling. Whatever had been there was now nests.

Cocoons of spiders. Webs of them. They hung—some many feet long, but none so large as ‘Toxivichere’, the queen of all horrors next to Allore.

“Dalimont. What is...”

“That would be a Dreamcatcher Spider, Your Highness. So named because they have the most incredible webs of any spider species. They create webs that were said to have snared Dragons in olden days. Unlike Shield Spiders, who grow without end, or the Spear Spiders of Baleros, these are trap-setters. Largely peaceful.”

“Largely.”

It was purple. She could see the fur moving on it, and the eyes of the Dreamcatcher Spider were a bright green. Oh, and it had fuzzy fangs as it slowly crawled up the huge strand of web it was hanging next to Allore on.

Small wonder the King of Bows was taking his time approaching the throne. He was clearly hoping the agitated spider, making a *chittering* sound by rubbing its legs together, would retreat. But Allore soothed his pet and compounded all of this into one moment that made it click with Seraphel.

“Toxivichere. *Hush.* Be a good, sweet thing.”

The spider turned to him—and he kissed it on its mandibles. It gently enfolded him with some of its legs—Mariel fainted backwards—and Allore blew a kiss.

The spiders rustled, charmed by the King of Hosts. Seraphel felt like her eyes were about to pop out of their sockets, and Dalimont spoke very, very quietly.

“I had...heard...that there were rumors about the King of Host’s infidelity. His relationship with Queen Nicterise is sometimes strained. But the exact...object...of his affections I didn’t give credence to.”

“He—th—”

“The [Princess] Kadane may be a shock to you, Princess. For the love of Calanfer, say nothing.”

What did that mean? There was no w—*King Allorev’s spiders were everywhere.*

They didn’t hang lower than the third floor, but if you looked up, you could see them. And apparently, the staff knew how to feed them by hanging food on the webs that rose upwards so the spiders could devour the morsels. The court?

No wonder there was a Landsreight for business. The nobles who were present looked either used to this or as if they were dying to pay their respects and leave. Now. *Let’s go. You go pay respects to him, I need a bath. Don’t eat anything, actually. I’ll burn my clothes after I—*is there something on my neck?

Anyone with arachnophobia would have a bad, bad—no, they were probably like Mariel. She woke up, began to have hysterics, and Dame Neranthei had to take her away.

Fortunately, it seemed like the court, staff, and Allorev were used to that kind of reaction. Thistel stayed with Seraphel, amazingly. She focused on Allorev and whispered.

“He does look magnificent, though, Your Highness.”

Seraphel was *amazed* her [Handmaiden] had time for fashion...then she eyed Allorev’s clothing and groaned.

“...That’s not silk.”

He was wearing *spiderwebs*. In fact, as he descended his throne to embrace Itreimedes, Seraphel got a good look at the thrones. And she realized they were made of bone.

White bone, the same black stone. The headrest was carved to look like a skull.

Dead. Gods. Imagine sitting in that! And Alloreve had dyed spiderwebs, which were reminiscent of silk. He looked like he was bleeding, and the effect made him almost appear like a [King] in regal red robes.

Then a corpse dyed crimson in blood. Then—a robed, graceful swan, dyed in red, as he swung around one of the female advisors he clearly knew and kissed the elderly woman’s hand as he swept her a bow.

Charming. Disturbing. And so fashionable he made Seraphel feel overdressed *and* underprepared.

That was King Alloreve. But the nuance was lost on most people. They tended to get stuck, understandably, on the spiders.

The spiders.

You didn’t get used to the spiders. You thought you might until you looked up and realized there were fifteen overhead, fat as melons, staring down at you.

And then you wondered if one landed in your drink. Or was in the food. *Was that a crawling in your throat? Could spiders lay eggs in your ears or hatch in your stomach? You’d heard stories that they could do that. Spiders, spiders, spiders, spiderspiderspidersspiders—*

Two more Thronebearers followed Neranthei. They were brave, trained to Calanferian etiquette, and the best bodyguards among [Knights] you could wish for.

They couldn't deal with the spiders. Seraphel herself had to use all her willpower not to keep feeling at her hair or dress. Dalimont's hand was white on his sword hilt as he bowed to King Allorev.

"Your Highness Seraphel. I salute you on your entry to the Court of Dusk. Not all can hold a polite veneer so well. Even King Reclis avoids this place. Did he warn you? Queen Ielane can dine without blinking, but she was always perfectly unshakeable."

Allorev in person was charming, amazingly direct, and intelligent. Seraphel bowed, trying not to glance up at the *giant spider* crawling above him.

"Your Majesty, I am honored by your kind words and invitation. My father did not mention the, ah, close friends you harbored directly."

"Too busy on matters of state, eh?"

Seraphel tried not to smile at that. Allorev watched as several royal letters were turned over from Dalimont to one of his people.

"I shall, of course, thank Their Majesties of Calanfer. The Eternal Throne's forbearance is marked and seen. Our failings in Afiele—you fare well for someone who has seen undead hordes for the first time. I apologize again. My forces took to the roads as soon as they heard the danger, and the Hunter's Guild mobilized, but slowly. They took a week to arrive; they were evacuating entire towns in the wake of what we thought to be a true horde. And a week was too late already for Lord Lantal and Lady Risel Afiele."

His eyes were sympathetic as he spoke to Seraphel, and at this, the court did listen in. The low voices in the center of the throne room were magnified by a trick of the acoustics, so you could hear them from the sides if no one else was speaking. Seraphel swallowed hard.

"I beg leave to tell you, Your Majesty, that Lord Lantal fought courageously to let my escort and I escape. No, he fought for his entire people to escape against such odds it was a miracle anyone survived. A rogue [Necromancer] —"

She almost said ‘hired by Ailendamus’, but Dalimont’s warning nudge made her stop. Allorev nodded, and the court murmured on the edges. Agitated.

“Despicable evil. As if the Hunter’s Guild was not worked hard enough. This tragedy—I cannot see how it was easily avoided, but my sympathies are endless for you and Calanfer’s heroism. And indeed that of Afiele and the folk there who repelled the undead. Stranger tidings I’ve heard of Afiele—but that is perhaps not a tale for now. I welcome you, Your Highness, and only wish Lord Fallien were here that he might greet his bride to be, properly.”

His words were a complex series of tells. Allorev was clearly a perfect courtier, as a man with his reputation surely had been, but what he showed and leaked and what Seraphel picked up were two different things.

He was clearly warning her not to talk about Afiele, but she thought he slipped with a grimace when he mentioned her husband-to-be. As for the Hunter’s Guild...Seraphel heard a murmur of discontent from more than one voice.

Yet the [King]’s pronouncement was also, clearly, in tandem with the latest news from Ovela. Because Allorev’s grimace became obvious for all to see.

“First Afiele, then Ovela. It appears the Landsreight must convene urgently. The Crown supports aid to both brave Afiele and to repel the Ailendamus incursions. Not war. Forgive me, [Princess] Seraphel, but your input would be welcome once the Landsreight is convened. If you would stay an hour upon our hospitality, I would be indebted to thee.”

He bowed his head, and Seraphel assured him she would stay. Then Allorev smiled.

“Wonderful. You are as poised as I had heard, Seraphel. And I hope you will learn the ways of the Court of Dusk, whether it be a day or week—after all, it seems to me you might take well to it. Possibly.”

“Your Majesty is too kind. And may I extend my warmest greetings to Her Majesty? Will I see her tonight or at a banquet?”

Allorev’s eyes shifted, and he sighed gustily.

“She is in no fit temperament. A poor season has Cathiel. I apologize for her, but Seratoito may appear. As for Kadane, she is doubtless around. But little Gedal? Where is he? Let him meet Her Highness.”

The boy, Prince Gedal, was four, and when a servant fetched him, he was holding a giant spider plushie...which promptly scuttled towards Allorev and carried the giggling boy over to His Majesty. Allorev hauled him onto his lap, and the boy was fascinated by Seraphel.

“She’s pretty!”

“Yes, she is! But don’t flirt. She’s to be married. Still, my son says what’s plain to see!”

Seraphel blushed and thanked Gedal for the compliment. Then wondered what kind of a boy grew up with a *pet spider*.

She was so dizzy she had to take a break by the buffet, but one look at a chicken egg and she wondered if it was filled with spiders...and promptly lost her appetite for good.

“Your Highness, have a drink of something clear. Purified water or perhaps a clear juice. One finds that’s the best remedy for the diet in the Court of Dusk. If I may be so bold, Princess. Duke Fiskren. An honor to meet you.”

A bluff man with a chestnut beard offered her a cup, and she took it with a shaking hand in relief. She looked up and found she was taller than he.

Duke Fiskren was short, stout, and looked like he could have been a [Woodcutter]. He had a broad axe of a nose, a jutting chin, and a walrus mustache that made him look much like a Dwarf.

But he was Human and friendly. His drink let Seraphel collect herself, and she bowed her head ever-so-slightly.

“Thank you, Your Grace. You have the advantage of me.”

“A small thing. Few are so composed. I well recall even His Majesty of Calanfer’s first moment in Noelictus was similar to this. Not that it has always been filled with King Allorev’s companions. In the past...it was far more shadowy.”

He confided, and Seraphel looked around the room in frank shock.

“Beg pardon, Duke Fiskren? With respect to Noelictus’ fine fashion—”

He chuckled as a few more people drifted over to speak to her.

“I have travelled abroad, and I think even Menorome is startled by the palace’s own colors, Your Highness. No—I truly meant shadowy. There was a time when the only light came from the ceiling, and moonlight amidst pure darkness meant you or I would miss filling our cups half the time. I cannot say the current ceiling puts me more at ease, but King Allorev has certainly brought his style here. A charming [King], isn’t he?”

“Oh, quite, absolutely. I am only sad I didn’t meet the Queen.”

Another voice, overly loud, broke in aggressively.

“Yes, well, a Kaazian [Prince] plays well at Noelictus royalty. But he sometimes speaks overly so for our beloved Queen Nicterise. Your Highness—I am Marquis Seelthru. An honor to meet you. I hope you will talk some sense into the Landsreight regarding all these indulgences of the Hunter’s Guild in light of these recent tragedies.”

Another man offered a hand, and she met Marquis Seelthru. Duke Fiskren didn’t look like he cared for the overly pale younger man in his thirties, and Seelthru had that energy of a young man. He was somewhat stooped with poorer posture, but he was over six and a half feet tall.

“Marquis Seelthru of Havens?”

He was pleased by her response and swept his flaxen hair back self-importantly.

“That’s correct. I’m pleased Calanferian royalty are as knowledgeable as they’re said to be. And perceptive and charming! King Alloreve certainly seemed to take *your* warning of Afiele seriously. Perhaps the Landsreight will find the spine to oppose him.”

“Marquis, you are involving Her Highness...we do not see eye-to-eye often, but you have my agreement in this at least.”

Duke Fiskren fumbled. He looked with more respect to King Alloreve bouncing his son on his knee on the throne, but Marquis Seelthru was far less covert in his sneer.

“We’ve been bled dry for those Hunter Cards, and for what? Ovela, an *Earl’s* domain, needs funding and soldiers. We should stop giving so much to the crown, and I hope you will vote with me.”

“Possibly. Your Highness, apologies. It’s all matters of the realm today. Though I suppose with your impending nuptials to Ovela it’s fitting to speak candidly.”

“Of course. I am concerned about Afiele—and Ovela! They have hardly survived the undead incursions, and any aid to the nobility would please me and Calanfer greatly.”

That made the two men nod and smile for different reasons, as it turned out. Marquis Seelthru raised his voice.

“The Landsreight should take back the gold that the crown spends so lavishly on the Hunter’s Guild.”

Fiskren countered almost instantly.

“And let each noble house divest it? I would much rather fund local Hunter’s Guilds and perhaps the army. Either way, Ovela cries for aid, and these Hunter’s Cards...”

Both men looked sour. Seraphel hesitated on a gentle reply.

“Not popular amongst the nobility?”

They were *exceptionally* rude within the earshot of the throne, and in Calanfer, they might have been taken as treasonous remarks for nobility of their position. But Seelthru glanced at Seraphel and chuckled.

“Ah, Calanferian tact. You need not be so couched in your language. Not here in the Court of Dusk. We prize honest emotions. Even His Majesty. But I must rally *my* support. Duke Fiskren—I expect cooperation.”

“We shall see.”

The other man eyed Seelthru with considerable distaste, then bowed to Seraphel.

“Your Highness, that was entirely rude of me. I apologize to your Calanferian sensibilities, but it is fitting in the courts. A second word of advice, if I may? Expressing your discontent for the spiders, if nothing else, will win you points, despite everything you may believe.”

With that he stepped away, and Seraphel was once again reminded her training was of little use in Menorome’s Court of Dusk. She did her best, but the next [Lady] looked her up and down as she stepped over.

“Your Highness, I am Lady Rizetine of Sovetn. I just wished to say I am pleased to meet you colorful Calanferians. I had always wished to visit the Eternal Throne.”

“Oh, I am delighted to meet you—”

“But I *object* to you marrying Lord Fallien. I am a fond supporter of Lady Pirai, and Calanfer putting their fingers to decide which is fit to be Earl of Ovela is disgusting! Shame on you, and, I might add, striding in here and lecturing His Majesty on where to send troops is the height of arrogance! Fiskren and Seelthru are well-intentioned at best, but they have no position censoring King Allorev. Queen Nicterise is the true daughter of Noelictus, and unless she says otherwise, our position is to support the monarchy!”

She gave Seraphel a fierce look, and the [Princess] was taken aback.

“I’m sorry, I was only relaying—”

“Oh, you’re *sorry*? Typical Calanferian backtalk. Now you listen to me—if you were really here to support your husband, you’d be at Ovela. But you’re not. So do us a favor and drop your sweet little act. I’ve heard the Cursed Princess was shuffled off here, and I’m only disappointed Lord Fallien took the bait. Honestly!”

Either she was drunk—or it was normal for a [Lady] to upbraid a [Princess] within earshot. Dismayed, Seraphel retreated, trying to get a word in edgewise.

Dalimont was no help. A [Knight] accosting a [Lady] was a bad look, and Seraphel began to get—angry as the woman pushed forwards, still bringing up that *nickname*.

But she saw Dalimont, Thistel, and the rest of her entourage giving her a worried, pleading look, and mindful of her duties, Seraphel bit her lip. It would be so easy if her parents had given her instructions *not* to let her tongue wag free! Because right now she just wanted to go off on this annoying [Lady].

Not if it endangered Afiele. But to Seraphel’s dismay, Lady Rizetine didn’t stop. She advanced, using her finger like a sword and practically pushed Seraphel towards some couches on one end of the throne room.

How anyone could relax, even on a settee, with the spiders overhead was a mystery. But Seraphel bumped against the couch, and someone sat up as Lady Rizetine continued her diatribe.

“*And furthermore*, where is this Calanferian generosity? A few [Knights] and no arms in and of itself? The Landsreight would be better served by questioning our ‘alliance’ with Calanfer if all we get is a single [Princess] who’s been remarried!”

Seraphel actually felt that one like a slap. Her head jerked, and her eyes stung—and she wondered if the [Lady] had a conversation Skill. It felt like one. She held herself back, thinking only of Culin and Sasi.

But the listener on the couch glanced at Seraphel's glittering eyes, then interrupted the two. She lifted a hand, and Rizetine hesitated.

"Oh—Your Highness—"

Seraphel turned and saw Princess Kadane lift her head up—twitch two languid fingers, and then wipe drool from her mouth.

And the two mandibles jutting out of her cheeks. Seraphel's mouth opened, and the [Princess], who had a spider's mandibles and oddly segmented hair and even the faintest *fur* on her olive skin, raised one finger.

"Rizetine, you blowhard. Is this how you treat a [Princess]? Get thee gone, *bitch*, and don't show your face in front of me. Or I'll bite you."

Then she snatched Seraphel's cup and tossed the drink all over Rizetine. The [Lady] exploded.

"*Kadane!*"

The [Princess] leapt from her sofa languidly, and Seraphel marveled at how she had planned her move. Rizetine was *dripping* with orange juice, and the [Princess] followed it up by flipping the woman's plate of food up, and half of it got down Rizetine's dress.

That was the nastiest move Seraphel had ever seen—and she had been at banquets with all her sisters going to war!

"Where's your respect for royalty?"

"*Your Majesty! Your daughter—*"

Rizetine strode away, and Kadane actually spat after her. Then she flopped down on her couch and raised her voice.

"Servants, another cup of wine for me! And you, [Princess]—you had better learn to talk back or you'll be walked over by any little [Lady] with a plot of land larger than a garden. Not that Rizetine's more than a jumped up Creler masquerading as a person, you see."

Her voice was loud, carrying, and only made the laughter at Rizetine's expense grow louder. Seraphel was still stuck on the...spider parts. Kadane noticed.

"Oh, and here we go. Are you horrified of me? Say so, please. I've had enough of horrified politeness when I was...three? This wine stains beautifully, and I have perfect aim."

She had a loaded winecup in hand as a spider-servant brought it over, and Seraphel hesitated. Everything in her training told her to smile and lie—but everything she had observed was telling her something else.

Maybe there was a reason she hadn't gotten a warning about her 'usual' methodology from Calanfer's majesties? Her mother often upbraided her for being snappish.

Unless in Noelictus... Seraphel took a gamble and hoped Ser Dalimont had learned how to deflect wine if she was wrong.

"The mandibles? I've seen far worse, Your Highness. You should see my sisters before makeup. And honestly, you're the first person who's defended me. So I *would* smile at a Creler before Lady Rizetine."

Princess Kadane raised her brows, and she nearly snorted wine out of her nose. Then she smiled with her mandibles even as she gulped.

"Ah, now there's the legendary Seraphel I heard of. It was worth dragging myself out of bed for this."

So they did know of her! Seraphel looked around and realized more people were drifting over.

"Wait, is the custom in Noelictus to be direct and pithy? I thought that was only Kaazian."

Now she remembered the Keeper's words, and Kadane laughed.

"How else? Do you think we're polite in this gloomy shithole of shadows? If you're in a bad mood, say it and be free. Some men like Fiskren can't

ever be truly unpleasant—but I heard you’d be fine company. Still, you were weak as a mouse until I stepped in. Cursed Princess?”

She smiled mockingly. This time, Seraphel just stared at Kadane.

“Yes, well, whoever said that of me in Calanfer clearly never met you, Princess Kadane. If you went abroad, I’d need a new nickname. With respect.”

The woman’s eyes widened—and then she threw back her head and laughed hugely.

“I like you! Do another, and I’ll show you around so you can see who to make miserable.”

She stood up lazily, and Seraphel blinked.

Wait a second. Am I actually in my element?

This...it felt like she had trained all her life for this. Thistel was staring at Dalimont, who was realizing there might have been another reason Seraphel was sent to Noelictus.

Two things shocked Seraphel. The first was that Princess Kadane liked her, and the second was that Kadane was a typical [Princess].

Typical in a pejorative sense, really. Kadane had been sleeping on the couch the entire time her father was greeting guests and holding court. She was no Sleeping Queen of Desonis, but she was fairly lazy.

And currently drinking wine for breakfast. She spoke to Seraphel out of the corner of her mouth.

“I don’t normally stay in court, but I wanted to meet you, and Father insisted we show our faces. Don’t look askance if I disappear. I’m either in the city, or *I can’t be bothered to do anything*. But promise me you’ll show

me some Calanferian fashion? I hear it's lace? To hang yourself with if you get bored of smalltalk?"

Seraphel whispered back as Kadane showed her around to her friends, mostly her age.

"It's all string. It flies well in a lot of courts, but between you and me, the *knots* are worth pretending ignorance over."

"Dreadful. Do you have anything else that's *new*?"

Kadane's voice was wistful, and instantly, Thistel and Dame Neranthei bowed.

"We do have a few samples, Your Highness. Perfumes from Pallass—a host of trinkets from Wistram's [Mages], and the Titan's board-game of chess is still popular across Izril."

Kadane scoffed.

"Oh, *that*. We're not behind in that. I just meant coastal goods. No one goes to Avel because it's all cliffs. And Pheislant isn't fond of sending as much our way. I hate chess. But let's see the perfumes."

Dame Neranthei produced a bottle that smelled like a violet haze of summer petals when just uncorked. Kadane recoiled slightly, then laughed.

"What a *fierce* scent! A drop of that would fill rooms! Who made it?"

"Pallass' top [Alchemist], Saliss of Lights."

"Oh, the famous Drake? I thought he only made explosive things."

Dame Neranthei leaned over conspiratorially, and Princess Kadane hid her mandibles behind a fan. She also had, Seraphel was certain, two rings of illusions on her fingers. Doubtless, those helped, but Kadane was comfortable enough to show her odd...

How would you even hide it? Did it interfere with eating? It didn't look like it.

“—a bet. Which he won against Alchemist Xif and produced this fragrance that had enough acclaim to be bought out by all the judges. Of course, Saliss of Lights insisted on putting one trapped vial in each shipment he sent. It would apparently explode, and it was filled with the odor of the sewers if you uncorked it...very hard to get rid of. Princess Menowhe of Pheisland was *very* upset.”

Kadane laughed so hard she nearly fell over.

“Serves her right! Wonderful, I didn't know why she didn't attend her own birthday! Delightful. I like those petty Drakes. And what's this?”

“It's a new board game, Your Highness.”

“*Not* chess?”

“No. ‘Go’, a game the Titan has personally endorsed.”

“I heard of that. Any of you have the rules and board? Of *course* you do. Give me one, would you? It will at least be fun to brag about. Seraphel, your [Knights] are far better than my dreary escort. Keeper Liletrec and my Shade Servants are not half as accommodating.”

“The Royal Keeper was...direct.”

Seraphel had to admit. Kadane snorted.

“Direct? She's a harridan. She'll insult you, tell you off for making a mess—she reports to my *mother*, and she can give even Father a hard time.”

That explained a lot. Queen Cathiel Nictorise was the technical ruler of Noelictus by right of blood. Even if King Nictor Allore had married in, the exigencies of a nation meant it would normally be his wife who ruled as the primary power, and he was technically simply the consort.

In practice...it seemed like Allorev had control of the court. *And once more, Seraphel would have loved to know the exact whys and wherefores of all this!*

Still, she had made a good impression on Kadane. She really was...a typical princess.

That meant she did not have Seraphel's training or duties. Oh, she was royalty and had come here because she was supposed to—but the contrast between Seraphel, who had perfect eating form, could talk Calanferian diplomacy, and make promises on behalf of the crown, and Kadane, who threw wine on people she didn't like, was telling.

She clearly enjoyed her position, but not the duties that came with it. Seraphel envied her that freedom, especially because Kadane was actually forty and unmarried.

"Who would want to marry me? Besides, I don't care for it, and Father and Mother don't press it. Seratoito's married Agshiga, and she'll be a good [Queen]. Though he's a snake. He'll meet you soon. The nation probably hopes that Gedal will get to be [King]. I'll let him do it so long as he doesn't kick me out of the palace."

Absolutely shocking statements. Kadane's remarks even got Duke Fiskren, talking with the other nobility, to turn and look askance. Seraphel couldn't help but like Kadane...and understand exactly why the royal court might not be happy with her.

"What about Afiele, Your Highness?"

"Oh, terrible. The Hunter's Guild normally takes down undead, but I suppose they had to wait for the army. Ovela? Troublemakers at war. Can't they just defend? Now they're asking for *our* help—Father will do his diplomacy thing. Don't ask *me* for support. Half the Landsreight would vote against me just on principle, and Seratoito's on the other side."

Kadane was not going to be an asset there, but having her friendship was good on another level. She did pull Dame Neranthei aside with an eager

group of young folk for more gossip and questions.

“Do you know about the ‘gelato’ everyone’s talking about, Dame Neranthei? No? Damn. It’s delicious. Frozen cream topped with blackberries...if even Calanfer can’t get it, that’s too bad. Some [Chef] refuses to say how he invented it.”

Calanfer had access to all kinds of gossip, trinkets, and treats. The fact that her mother hadn’t gotten the recipe for the frozen custard dish that was taking Terandrian courts by storm was a sore point, Seraphel knew.

She was about to see if she could spot the first [Prince] when Dalimont stepped over.

“Your Highness, your father. I have selected a secured room for you.”

He had a room ready and had doubtless warded it for privacy’s sake. Seraphel knew Thronebearers were second to none in the arts of covertness, so she took the glowing opal he handed her, set in a silver brooch, and stepped into a private room.

There, she talked to her father.

[Communication] spells were far more difficult to cast and expensive to maintain than the simple [Messages]—and even those had to be run through the Academy of Mages and were out of the means of commonfolk.

However, royalty had access to both, and of course, Dalimont had a brooch that could reach back to Calanfer. It probably had to go through multiple relays, so it wasn’t as if Seraphel could simply talk to her parents in Afiele where the Mage’s Guild only let her send [Messages].

But in Menorome, her parents could talk to her if the need was great enough. So King Reclis spoke to his daughter for the first time since the siege.

About matters of court.

“Seraphel! It is good to hear you’re well. Dalimont just updated me on the situation in the Court of Dusk. Well done. I knew you’d figure out the rules, and it sounds like you’ve made a wonderful impression.”

“Father?”

Seraphel’s throat constricted for a second. It was rare he ever contacted her abroad. But King Reclis was still speaking.

“I hope you weren’t taken aback by the spiders. You’ve enjoyed Menorome with the allowance we sent.”

“Father! You didn’t mention anything about the Court of Dusk! Much less that they appreciate direct speaking! I nearly got chewed out before I caught on!”

He chuckled softly.

“They also appreciate genuineness, Seraphel. I had faith you’d figure out the game, and it’s far more impressive for a [Princess] to show she has fangs than to go in knowing everything. Poise, Seraphel. We aren’t known as Calanferian diplomats because we’re always prepared. You were pressed—you figured out what to do, and took down a member of the Court of Dusk on their turf. That’s an impression. And it seems like Nicte and Kadane both were impressed.”

Seraphel massaged her forehead slowly, trying not to snap. Now it made sense. Her father would never let her make a quiet splash when he could get results.

“Actually, Ielane suggested all of it. She knows you better than I. Now, to business. Ovela is being pushed hard by Baron Digneral du Ecte. I’m not quite certain that Nicte or the Landsreight understand just how bad it is.”

Seraphel’s stomach flopped. She motioned, and Dalimont produced a sheet.

“I already have the details to present. It is...eight battalions of Ailendamus armor, Your Majesty. Over his standing forces, and Ovela just finished a

rather bloody engagement where they pushed his forces back. They have their famous Hammer of Ovela, and the keep is unlikely to be taken, but Digneral is storming forwards and essentially razing everything he can reach besides the keep. If he continues, he might literally encircle it.”

Eight battalions? That sounded quite bad. Seraphel swallowed, and she knew that if Ovela was under siege, the counties bordering the main province would be next.

That meant Afiele. Hadn't Culin and Sasi been supposed to present themselves to...? No, no. Duchess Grishen was there, and Seraphel focused hard on the present.

“I will rally as much support as I can, Father.”

He sounded surprised and gratified.

“Good! I was afraid I'd have to get your mother to twist your arm. Mayhaps I'm thinking of Aielef. We still haven't found Lyonette, you know. I'm afraid the girl really is in Izril...ah, well, we can't be loud. Not a word on that. Now, be very certain to seek out the following men and women, Seraphel. First is Duke Fiskren...”

“I've met him. I think he's all for support.”

“Good. He's part of the anti-indulgences faction, though. Not the pro-noble ground of Marquis Seelthru, and be very careful to tie yourself to Fiskren. We need to push Alloreve here, a bit. He doesn't want to give the nobility more power, and that's fair, but he does like to spend on his Hunter's Guild. I love my Thronebearers too, but he spends a fortune on them! He won't like you taking sides against him, but he knows the game. I'm prepared to send a purse in support of the crown. I suggest you hold onto that until they turn on you and ask what Calanfer is doing...”

King Reclis gave Seraphel instructions for fifteen minutes, then sent her back out to work. Kadane rolled her eyes when she saw Seraphel

approaching the Landsreight.

They were able to vote and convene in a separate part of the palace, a grand and fanciful place where each member could enter a room that literally had a map of Noelictus carved into the floor.

But for two spots, Noelictus had kept every single piece of land for ages, and it had ancient ties. Each noble, then, had a vote corresponding to their province's size and, often, whether or not they were tenders of a tomb.

It was all very Noelictan, and Seraphel didn't have to count votes. She just spoke to the people present, dropping facts about the size of the invading forces, Calanferian aid—contingent on Noelictus rallying around Ovela—and Afiele's own recent attacks.

“Eight battalions? That's no skirmish. That's an *invasion*.”

Duke Fiskren nearly crushed his cup when he heard that. But a worried [Countess] murmured as he raised his voice.

“Do you want to declare all-out war with Ailendamus? They have *legions* of [Knights]. Ovela's held them off before. If anything, I blame the Twins for attacking Ailendamus!”

“They claim several miles of land past one of the rivers are ours. Which may be so. Either way, they have the Hammer of Ovela and the Ovelian Keep—but how are we to muster a force large enough to quell *eight* battalions? Do we invoke the army?”

“The simplest way would be to send [Hunters]. They're our [Knights], but they refuse to enter the warfront at all. Better than the spending on their precious indulgences and cards.”

That came from Marquis Seelthru, who sneered into the conversation. Fiskren bristled, but he gave a grudging nod.

The Landsreight was interesting. Seraphel was used to trustworthy and incompetent [Lords], ambitious socialites and self-interested hangers-on,

and every variation between.

What was interesting about Noelictus was that it was oddly united. Normally, in Calanfer, any faction of the nobility struggled to codify their varied interests, and the King of Diplomacy had them both inclined to support his goals and too weak to make trouble.

Allorev was a charming man. But less of a statesman, it seemed.

Or perhaps the issues were so large even his charm couldn't win the full support of his nobility.

“Just what *are* these indulgences, Duke Fiskren? I've heard of them and seen the Hunter's Cards, but the Landsreight seems agitated about them.”

Seraphel could play on her ignorance, and the Duke was only too happy to explain, albeit with a grimace.

“It must seem odd to you, but the [Hunters] of Noelictus are no [Knights], Your Majesty. They kill undead, often solo, and it is a dire, thankless job. I don't recall when the practice started—generations back—but the crown decreed they should be allowed ‘indulgences’ for their hard work. Funds to rest, relax, indulge in Menorome's comforts. Is that unheard of, Ser Knight?”

He turned to Dalimont, and the man bowed.

“Not at all, Duke Fiskren. Thronebearers do enjoy the benefits of serving the crown. In moderation.”

It was a smart comment. Several of Fiskren's faction muttered darkly. Fiskren sipped from his cup, eying King Nicté Allorev, who was still yet on the throne, talking to his son but watching the Landsreight moving into their parliament. He did have his supporters, but they were largely engrossed in arguments. Nor did it seem like Fiskren hated King Nicté. He just...sighed.

“Moderation. That *is* the word. The Hunter's Cards are the step too far for many. They are cards you can give to any shopkeeper or most [Merchants]

in Noelictus. Some are only a few gold coins. The ones for the Veteran Hunters...hundreds.”

“And they all get one?”

Fiskren’s nod said it all. Seraphel bit her lip.

What a huge amount of money! Was King Nichte worried the Hunter’s Guild had diverse loyalties or something? That was a great concern for some nations, but Marquis Seelthru broke in.

“The theory is that it invigorates Menorome, and our capital certainly does prosper, but *I* am sick of paying for our [Hunters]. Only the capital practices the indulgences and card-system. As Duke Fiskren will tell you, *his* Hunter’s Guild uses neither. I would rather we support the Twins in Ovela.”

“And cut tithes to the crown by a quarter?”

“War demands we distribute our wealth differently, Duke Fiskren.”

The Marquis’ tone was very carefully neutral, but Seraphel’s back prickled. *Now there is a dangerous man to have so much support behind.*

There were numerous examples of times when the monarchy had been held hostage by its nobility. She was beginning to get a better picture of Menorome’s politics, and it occurred to Seraphel suddenly that paying the Hunter’s Guild so well might have more than one benefit.

Loyalty, for instance, in case the nobility got stropky.

Still, it was a mess, and it was only compounded when Seraphel saw a man striding through the crowd, parting the Landsreight, who either regarded him with fondness or pure disdain. Duke Fiskren glared—and Marquis Seelthru beamed.

“Ah, and here is the one member of the crown who understands. Your Highness, may I present Prince Seratoito, our voice of reason?”

Seratoito made Seraphel uneasy the moment she met him. To paint a picture of him—he was no Kadane with obvious spider-mandibles. In fact, he had paler skin than hers, a classic Noelictan lack of sunlight.

His hair, as was sometimes the case in Noelictus, was bleached of color, a blond going white, but he was probably only in his mid-thirties, the younger of Kadane by a few years. He was also shorter than his sister, and thus Seraphel, by a good bit.

If that bothered him, well, Duke Fiskren was commanding enough at similar height. Unlike the Duke, Seratoito was far less fit, but he had a bold stride of confidence.

That might have also had to do with the fact that the woman who followed him like a polite shadow was Huntress Agshiga, one of the most high-level [Hunters] in Noelictus. Commander of the Royal Deathhunt—and dangerous.

Dalimont's slight tensing next to Seraphel told her that. The Huntress bowed politely, as if she were a servant or bodyguard, not a member of the royal family by marriage, when Seratoito met Seraphel.

"Your Highness. I am distressed not to meet a fair flower of Calanfer already! It is an honor to meet you and a pity about Afiele. Alas, I was caught up in a diversion, but it would be my honor to dine with you. Marquis Seelthru! Are we convening the Landsreight again? Tiresome, tiresome. You'd think Father would know better than to drag you all here and keep you voting."

"Your Highness, you are a breath of fresh air."

Seraphel smiled, and Seratoito snorted as he and the Marquis jested friendly.

"Not according to Father."

His wide smile turned into a sneer of frustration—and then he hid it. Seraphel didn't react, though Fiskren grimaced, and Seelthru pretended not

to notice.

Oh, that's not good. She had been taught by her mother to mask her emotions, but Seratoito was very, very bad at it. Self-taught...and he let slip a rift with his father so fast that Seraphel only needed to listen to him for ten minutes to get a read on him.

It was very obvious that if Kadane was the lazy [Princess]—Seratoito was the ambitious, frustrated [Prince] who cultivated rich friends like the Marquis of Havens. And he was inclined to back his friends since he had no direct route to the throne.

Everything about him was actually textbook in the warning signs that King Reclis would have looked for in his own sons. *Rift with the father, expensive tastes*—he practically grabbed Dalimont when the [Knight] mentioned he had the latest board games and news.

“*That* is the stuff of Calanfer right there, Ser Dalimont. I have said it time, time, and time again. If Noelictus had a port city, Menorome would be a universal wonder, not the local jewel. Do you have anything for me if my sister is getting perfume?”

“Your Highness, I could offer you vintages from Izril. Amentus wine?”

Seratoito laughed in delight.

“*Poison wine.* If it's made wrong. I love it. Sweet as sugar, and you could be dead if it's a bad glass. Let's have a banquet at my estates. Seelthru, you'll have to come.”

The Marquis was less happy about drinking the famous, sweet, *blue* wine made of poisonous fruit.

“I, ah, may be busy with the affairs of my lands for now, Your Highness, but I shall attend another of your wonderful parties very soon.”

“Oh, very well. Some men have no taste for the exotic. I, on the other hand, welcome some Calanferian largesse into the courts, Your Highness. If I'm

found dead with Amentus wine on my mouth, don't blame anyone but the [Vinter]!"

He had a dark sense of humor, too. But Huntress Agshiga interjected at this point amidst the uncomfortable laughter.

"Poison won't claim you, my dear."

She smiled at Seratoito, then hid the smile as she pulled down her iconic hat, flushing slightly. Seratoito glanced at Agshiga and winked at Seelthru.

"Alas, my own [Hunter] is proof against poison and arms."

"At least one member of the Hunter's Guild seems to be putting her time at work serving the crown."

Seelthru murmured back, and the two men clicked glasses. Seraphel, watching Agshiga standing still without taking any wine, thought she was definitely *not* being treated like royalty. Then she heard a too-loud whisper from Seratoito in Seelthru's ear thanks to her Skill.

"That's why you give them indulgences, Seelthru. Agshiga's a delightful protector *and* indulges in lust—which is fun for married life, I'll admit."

The two men started laughing so hard that Seraphel had to step back and take a breath. She glanced at Agshiga, and the [Huntress] was faintly red as Duke Fiskren finished his entire goblet and headed off for a second.

Okay, Noelictus had more problems than she thought. It was very clear that Seratoito was both supportive of the nobility, at least when it came to his own supporters, and enjoyed the capital's lavish spending.

All while their border province was up in flames. Why wouldn't they...

"—send [Hunters] to the frontlines? Oh, Your Highness. Menorome would be filled with the dead if not for them!"

Seratoito waved the notion off in a second. Seelthru hesitated.

“Surely not if we sent a handful of Veteran Hunters...”

Seratoito wagged a finger.

“[Hunters] are excellent bodyguards and slayers of monsters alone, but they don’t practice rank and formation, Seelthru. Besides, do you know how often they have to put down undead in the sewers or make sure some old fellow passing away in his sleep doesn’t gnaw on his grandchildren? Agshiga does remind me—I’d rather send [Soldiers] than a Veteran Hunter. One kills undead. The other kills people. Let’s not separate function, eh?”

The Marquis and Seraphel had to concede that one, even if Seraphel thought that non-specialists who could kill Draugr would do a *fine* job against [Soldiers] if used right. The Marquis sourly sucked on his teeth.

“If we have to all levy troops—”

“Well, perhaps we should accompany that with a cut on your taxes, eh? And if you have complaints, I’ll hear you out, Seelthru. My father won’t listen, but I may.”

And here came a backdoor deal right in the open. Seelthru’s eyes brightened at the tax cut, and he and his faction gathered around Seratoito as Fiskren objected. Seraphel looked on with dismay.

What a dysfunctional court. Then King Nichte Alloredev appeared and had his say.

King Alloredev’s presence was charming. Even when the Landsreight disliked what he was going to make them do, he, personally, had a friendship that exceeded even her father’s sway.

“Fiskren, are you going to make another objection? Your daughter, incidentally, deserves congratulations on taking down a Draugr yesterday. Do you worry about her? Seratoito, stop dragging Marquis Seelthru away. I

heard about the Havenward Tomb being damaged by [Hunters]. I personally summoned Guildmistress Deilfec to chastise her on that.”

“Ah, my citizens complain, but Your Majesty needn’t...*agitate* the good Guildmistress on my behalf.”

Marquis Seelthru looked pleased, nonetheless, and Seraphel thought of Afiele’s tomb. One had been damaged? But King Nichte assured the man calmly.

“It’s sealed at least, but these were my personal feelings, which she took in stride. I trust my son is keeping you good company? Huntress Agshiga, you put up with Seratoito well. I should like to see you more often in my halls.”

She smiled, touching her hat as Seratoito glared into his cup.

“When I am not with the [Prince], my hunting duties call, Your Majesty.”

“Spoken like a true [Hunter] of Noelictus!”

King Nichte was approving, and it was hard to gainsay him there. So he was clever—but the Landsreight’s fondness for their famous [Huntress] didn’t mean they would back down easily.

Seraphel listened to the arguments as they went down that hall. More than one noble stood on the border of Ovela, pointing down as if to show them all the ancient map in the floor being threatened by Ailendamus at this very moment.

“Your Majesty, we *must* cut these Hunter’s Cards and support Ovela! What will we do if it falls?”

“The Twins make their bed ignoring peace. Their father was much more reasonable—and much more often did he stand here and debate his position in the Landsreight’s halls. Wouldn’t it be fair to say that our beloved Twins cause too much trouble trying to decide who should be the Earl once and for all?”

King Nichte returned calmly. Lady Rizetine winced and agreed.

“They are reckless, I admit, but Ovela *cannot* fall.”

The [King] walked back to rest on his throne, in the center of the room, representing Menorome.

“No indeed. But I do not think the [Baron] of Ailendamus will push beyond Ovelian borders. I would rather not send the army and give Ailendamus *reason* to declare war. Rather, it would befit me more if concerned members of the Landsreight were to send an appropriate force to check the Baron’s ambitions.”

Instantly, half the court protested, but King Allorev silenced them all before continuing.

“—In recognition of your depleted forces, the royal army might station a garrison where needed to slay monsters and keep the peace. And an appropriate cut be made to the season’s taxes. Since I hear a number of voices demanding some concessions.”

He turned, and his eyes met Seratoito’s, and annoyance flashed between both men. Seraphel just listened, in awe at the casual discourse. The Court of Dusk truly was informal it seemed!

Then again, this was a debate, and the [King] had to *convince* the Landsreight to vote to accept his will. It was Duke Fiskren who objected, here.

“Your Majesty. What of the [Hunters]? I have heard time and time again from Lord Fallien that keeping Ailendamus at bay demands Noelictus’ blood. [Hunters]...”

“...Are busy keeping the peace in Noelictus. Nor do I think Lord Fallien would mind having more [Soldiers] to order around. Once again, I ask whether he is responsibly using them to guard Ovela’s borders—or whether he should have given troops to Lord Lantal when Afiele needed him most. As I understand it, he was not there even when Duchess Grishen slew the [Necromancer]. The *capital*’s army was at Afiele when Earl Fallien’s forces had already left. And you’d give him [Hunters], Lord Fiskren? Truly?”

The Duke fell silent as heads turned to Seraphel, and she heard her to-be husband's name once more with a pang. Allorev lifted a hand.

"I am not minded to give the Twins more forces at *all*."

"But what about the armies of Ailendamus—"

His eyes were direct as he met Fiskren's gaze.

"I propose this. In light of the attacks, Ailendamus should not take Ovela's keep. The Twins have a powerful army, but this aggressive raid threatens all of Noelictus' east. Afiele has suffered enough. So to Afiele I say: station forces around Ailendamus. They advance not one step more into surrounding lands, and if they do surround the Ovelian Keep—"

"We fall on them from all sides. It may be sound, Your Majesty."

Fiskren allowed slowly, and the members of his faction murmured agreement. Seraphel's heart eased to hear the proposal to defend Afiele at least—but she knew her father might object to this agreement.

A [King] at odds with his nobility, the Hunter's Guild overfat, a scheming [Prince], a lazy [Princess], and the [Queen] not to be seen.

Oh, what a mess. Seraphel listened, and the Landsreight finished haggling after six hours to do mostly what had been proposed, but when she returned, overweary from her first visit to Noelictus' courts, Seraphel had to report to her parents before she could sleep.

They were not fully pleased, but then, neither was she.

And the problems of Menorome only seemed to grow after her sleep.

Seraphel had made enough of a positive impression that she was given a permanent invitation to the Court of Dusk until the Ovelian conflict was resolved.

She was due to wed Lord Fallien when she arrived there, but given the war—that meant she had at least another week in Menorome.

As it so happened, a lot could happen in between heading to court, entertaining Princess Kadane, greeting King Allorev, and meeting with the nobles and singing with Cara until she fell asleep.

Two major events happened that week. The first was that Princess Seraphel got to speak with the other foreign royalty in Menorome.

King Itreimedes she knew. He didn't take part in the Landsreight, and indeed, he'd left the courts after greeting King Nicte. He was here on vacation and seemed quite uninterested in the war.

"The war? Oh, we're friendly with Noelictus. Old ties and all that, but Nicte's always sparring with his lands...thing. Myself, I'm hunting. Some Marquis invited me, and I haven't hunted in Noelictus for an *age*. They crave my attention, even in Noelictus. And you say my own court hates me!"

He turned to his advisors, and one gave Itreimedes a warning look.

"Your Majesty, I'm sure Her Highness doesn't want to hear about your social life. Nor do I think—"

He fell silent after a second, and Seraphel read between the lines. *Nor do I think the nobility just loves you unconditionally.* She had a feeling she knew which Marquis was courting the King of Avel. You would want the friendship of the King of Bows if...

No, that was too obvious. But she was thinking of Prince Seratoito, and Avel was their western border. King Itreimedes, at any rate, was oblivious as could be. He yawned.

"Well, I often come to Menorome, Your Highness. For diversions. It seems there are less and less fun ones, or perhaps that's just growing old."

“If you refuse to get off a horse or actually do anything, of course you can only sleep or eat. Your fat Majesty.”

Maybe Noelictus had learned their rudeness from Avel! King Itreimedes turned slowly to the senior [Advisor].

“This is insubordination before a [King]. Your Highness, you see what I have to put up with?”

“...The Minister of Defense certainly is strident, Your Majesty.”

King Itreimedes hesitated, and the [Advisor]’s eyes flashed.

“That would be me.”

“Oh, is that why you give me so much backtalk? Fine, *minister away*. I let them run the affairs of Avel, and they think they can tell me what to do. I only let them do it because I have more important things to do.”

Then he was on his way, and Seraphel was shaking her head at another nation that somehow ran decently well.

Pheislant to the south, Ailendamus to the east, and Avel to the west. Each one a different nation, and Avel was a prosperous, if somewhat closeted kingdom like Noelictus. Behind the scenes, though, Seraphel was getting a sense that all was *not* perfect in Noelictus. Hadn’t Lord Lantal been so very poor?

Seeing the riches of Menorome, she had to believe that King Nichte’s favoritism of his Hunter’s Guild was not all that wise, even if the man himself was affable. But then again, each nation had flaws, and Calanfer had a runaway [Princess], so a dysfunctional royal family was to be expected.

But any nation might look poor compared to its northern neighbor of Samal, the locked Kingdom of Keys, paradise in Terandria. A nation that was literally called a living utopia where no one died of violence.

Kingdom of Keys. Seraphel had visited the outskirts, but no more than that; foreign diplomats were lucky to get past the border, and Samal was beyond reclusive. It was powerful, and some of its [Knights] were famous for crusading abroad, but like many paradise-nations, the true strength of Samal was its self-sufficiency—and the fact that no army had managed to take it easily.

Samal, Khelt, the Isle of Archmages, and so on—all had incredible defenses. In the Kingdom of Keys' case, it was literal barriers, magical and metal. They loved keys, if that was not obvious.

Seraphel expected to do nothing with the Kingdom of Keys, but as it so happened, one of their own royal members was in Noelictus.

Princess Telleis was a Gold-rank adventurer. She had not abandoned her royal duties; it was more like she was so free of concerns that she was allowed to become one. She had developed a name for herself as a dashing duelist with her keyword, and she was the *second*-most eligible bachelorette in Terandria.

She was like a [Battle Princess] out of stories. Whereas Duchess Greina, her close friend, was short and stocky, Telleis was the model of conventional beauty for many [Ladies].

She didn't even have to put on much makeup. Seraphel couldn't *help* but note that when the Duchess and Princess appeared in court the second day she was there.

Duchess Greina was also a force to be reckoned with. Her personal aura felt like a manifestation of herself. She walked around with a permanent sphere of personality such that people would begin moving out of her way even ten feet away.

She could, Seraphel understood, block arrows just by manifesting her will, and the two *younger* women were terribly intimidating to Seraphel.

“Your Highness. It's a pleasure to meet you. I journey with Greina's team, *Noble Spirit*, and we roam as adventurers in Noelictus these days. We were

dreadfully horrified to hear of Afiele and the disaster there. If we hadn't been in Samal—you are quite poised to come out of it so gracefully.”

“You flatter me, Princess Telleis. And you, Duchess Greina, astound me with that weapon!”

The arbalest-style crossbow that Greina carried was wider than Seraphel from shoulder to shoulder! The woman grinned as she unslung it. Then hesitated.

The bodyguards wearing masks stirred on the other end of the throne room. Greina hurriedly put the crossbow back on her back.

“Ah, I forget myself. I have dispensation to walk with it in the throne room, and His Majesty graces me too much with it.”

Letting Duchess Greina carry a crossbow really was a sign that she was favored by the throne. Then again, Duke Fiskren was a loyal citizen.

But even the Thronebearers only kept their blades because they were her bodyguards. Few others were allowed weapons, and Seraphel mentioned that. Greina laughed, embarrassed.

“It's not just because I'm a trusted adventurer. I made the mistake of bringing the crossbow in the day I got it, and His Majesty's guards nearly stabbed me. But Queen Nicterise was so taken she asked me to let her fire it. Then she gave me royal dispensation, nay, an *order* to carry it in her halls. So long as I can fire it. I think she's forgotten, but for Her Majesty—”

What an odd woman. And still, Seraphel hadn't heard a peep from Queen Cathiel Nicterise at all.

It was like everyone knew about her, including Reclis and Ielane, and yet if it was a secret—it was not one Seraphel was expected to figure out. Reclis had simply described Cathiel as ‘better left alone’ and told Seraphel to focus on Alloreve. Greina sighed.

“Having a bad season, I understand.”

Telleis seemed as puzzled as Seraphel, but she smiled, bowed, and watched as Ireimedes left the courts.

“His Majesty of Avel is here for holiday, I understand. We are more resting, but this is the second time I’ve been in Menorome for an extended period since I was a girl. We normally fight undead, you see, Your Highness.”

That sounds dreadful. Seraphel smiled.

“Astonishingly brave, Princess. While you are here, are you going to avail yourself of the city?”

“I don’t fancy sleeping, and frankly, Samal imports a number of fine cultures around the world.”

The [Princess] gave Seraphel a polite smile, which Seraphel couldn’t help but interpret as, ‘we have everything you do and more, even for Calanfer’.

She tried not to bristle, and Greina sighed.

“Telleis, you’re being superior.”

The [Princess of Keys] instantly colored and grew flustered.

“No, I’m not! Am I? I do apologize, Princess Seraphel. I just meant— Greina, you suggest something.”

“I’m trying. The problem is Samal does have everything and anything. That’s paradise for you. They even had our Sleeping Parlors...the Nightrain is just fun for riding once...”

“May I suggest the Synphasia Theatre, perhaps? I was quite taken by it when I visited.”

Seraphel couldn’t *help* but slide the suggestion in, and Princess Telleis looked interested. Greina was reluctant. She addressed Seraphel with frankness that the 4th Princess found refreshing.

“I am glad, Your Highness. But frankly, the venue has somewhat declined. The current half-Elf is a touchy master, and I have yet to listen to a masterpiece. I’d rather not gamble on a wasted hour, if that makes sense.”

“I completely understand. We were fortunate that he performed—but there is another act, a performer called, ah, Cara? A [Singer], you know. Duchess of the Dance—she’s quite taking even if the main act does not perform. I quite liked her performance.”

Seraphel turned faintly red as her escort gave her a knowing look, and Dalimont’s face was blank—but she bet he was smiling inwardly as she recommended her friend to the adventurers.

It would do Cara some good if she had noble patrons, and a few other listeners in the court also looked interested.

“If she impressed a [Princess] of Calanfer—why not? Let’s go tonight, Greina. Thank you, Your Highness.”

“Oh, think nothing of it. And please, prevail on me for anything while I am here. Samal is often a fond memory for my father, King Reclis.”

Telleis wasn’t fooled by that. Everyone loved to court Samal, but she gave Seraphel a duelist’s bow.

“Thank you, and I shall bear it in mind, Your Highness.”

The next evening, Seraphel was coming back from a tiring day of entertaining Prince Seratoito. In theory, he was entertaining her at his mansion, but he was a self-centered narcissist who was clearly eager to gain fame abroad...if only he could gain more authority from his father.

That was abundantly clear from his marriage to Huntress Agshiga. For some reason, the woman doted on *him*—but perhaps that was the admiration of a citizen for the monarchy. Seratoito had even invited Dalimont to duel Agshiga.

“Dalimont, how is your arm? She didn’t break it, did she?”

The Thronebearer was massaging his hand with a grimace.

“That would be my good arm, Your Highness. And she did not...but I would bet the Huntress is at least Level 40. I don’t think she realized how weak I was.”

He looked ashamed, and Seraphel blew out her cheeks.

“It made Seratoito happy you lost, so consider it part of your duties anyways. You’ve been practicing with your sword in secret every night. Was it that much of a difference?”

Dalimont turned red, having not known she was aware of his doings in the courtyard. It was Dame Neranthei who answered for him.

“She would be...a match for anyone but the Lightherald or the most senior [Knights] in the Thronebearers.”

“*Really.*”

“She is incredible.”

Dalimont acknowledged slowly. He shook out his hand.

“Those twin swords she uses are not for show. She used *one*, and she overwhelmed me while I had a sword and shield. And nearly broke my arm while hitting my shield.”

“That’s impressive?”

“That’s impressive.”

Her [Knights] assured her Agshiga was the real deal. Seraphel flopped into a chair as she entered her mansion. Despite having rented a rich place in the Sovereign District, she felt dirt-poor compared to Seratoito’s wealth. He had that black stone all over his estates, which was apparently imported

from a mine in Chandrar that was the only place you could get it. *And* far too many self-portraits, gifts from Marquis Seelthru and his friends.

“All that power—and not one Hunter went to Afiele. And the wealth in Seratoito’s mansion! The Palace of Shadows isn’t half so opulent! You know, I quite like Kadane. She’s not much for ruling, but she’s good-hearted, just self-conscious about the fangs.”

She mimed the mandibles. Seraphel glared as Dalimont and the staff busied themselves around her, but listened.

“I’ve even gotten used to the spiders. Somehow. The court is rather gloomy, but King Nicte—I mean, King Allorev is charming. Menorome *is* beautiful, and I wouldn’t mind living here for a bit. But that [Prince] is odious, and they really do spend too much on their [Hunters], to hear Fiskren talk. He seems honest. What’s your read on the palace?”

She looked around, and Thistel held up a hand.

“...I like it, Your Highness. I was afraid of the spiders too, but it really is so...*stylistic*.”

“You’re mad. I can’t bear to be in the throne room, Your Highness. All that darkness—I’d kill for a day in the sun!”

“Well, perhaps we’ll visit Avel or stand outside Samal and beg for keys.”

Seraphel sighed. That would be her life unless her husband wanted her by his side. She pushed that aside.

“Even so. Dalimont, can you tell me if you think Fiskren isn’t just a bluff, honest fellow?”

The [Knight] hesitated as he poured a bit of healing potion on his bruised hand.

“...I am not the most skillful disassembler amongst my Order, Your Highness—”

“Answer the question and stop effacing.”

She rolled her eyes, and he shrugged.

“Then I shall agree that I think he is a loyal, hard-working [Duke]. I would be gratified if we had a dozen men like him in Calanfer.”

Seraphel sat forwards, resting her chin in her hands.

“...Then why is it so hard to answer his complaints? King Nicte really must indulge his Hunter’s Guild. He certainly loves diversions. But Duke Fiskren seems reasonable, and even Marquis Seelthru’s issues, self-serving as they are, have merit.”

“Some monarchs simply have their delights, Your Highness. King Ireimedes is going a bit to...seed.”

“He’s gained fifty pounds, you mean. But King Nicte isn’t enjoying it all himself.”

“...Perhaps he’s afraid of the Guildmistress? Even the Marquis and other nobility were scared of her. She visits the court sometimes, and apparently she could stare down a Gorgon.”

Seraphel groaned.

“Another spitfire? Wonderful. Who is held hostage by their own *Guild*?”

Dame Neranthei hesitated.

“It’s not analogous, but a Named-rank adventurer can often threaten a weaker ruler, Your Highness. If the Guild is too strong...”

“I see. Well, they’re sending forces to Ovela, and as soon as I hear Culin and Sasi aren’t at Ovela, I shall rest easy. I just wonder—did King Nicte *really* sleep with...”

“Shh! Your Highness!”

Thistel shushed Seraphel as Dalimont turned his head, but Seraphel waved it off.

“Don’t shush me! This is the only place I can gossip, and we’re *all* thinking of it. Can you actually do that with a spider? Even if you had fertility charms that different species use...really? That would explain why Her Majesty doesn’t appear—”

“Your Highness! Someone’s at the door!”

Then Seraphel fell silent, because while the Thronebearers were good at keeping this house from being monitored—that only held true so long as no one else was in it. And as it happened, someone else knew that this was one of the only places you could gossip without being overheard.

“Cousin!”

Princess Telleis greeted Seraphel, looking slightly embarrassed as the [Princess] eyed the entire team of Greina’s adventurers, Noble Spirit.

Which was just Telleis, Greina, and two Lizardpeople. They waved at Seraphel, holding their spears excitedly as Seraphel stared. And she noticed the group had one more addition.

Is that a [Hunter]? A young woman, barely twenty, with white hair and their iconic hat and armor was standing nervously behind Greina, looking as confused as Seraphel felt.

“Oh, Princess Telleis. Can I help you?”

The [Princess] of Samal looked slightly flustered, and Seraphel was definitely unsure why Telleis was here. They had played nice in court, but it wasn’t like they were instant friends. Telleis cleared her throat.

“I just wanted to first say—thank you for your comments in court the other day. I was most delighted by the *Synphasia*’s recommendation, cousin Seraphel. It was a splendid performance. That [Singer] you mentioned was

indeed phenomenal. His Majesty of Avel was also there and quite enjoyed his second visit, I understand.”

Seraphel blinked. Then smiled, because that meant Cara had done well! And Ireimedes had gone there again?

“Was it? Oh, that’s—well, wonderful. Er, how can I help you?”

She wasn’t trying to be rude, but she knew that Telleis was not here to just report she’d had a fun time watching the performance. The [Princess] hesitated, then bowed deeply. She lowered her voice, and Seraphel’s intrigue-senses began going off like crazy.

“Could we prevail on your private parlor, Seraphel? We’re discussing something private, and there was no one else I could turn to. I’ll repay the favor, of course.”

Seraphel’s eyes flickered, and her first thought was...*oho. This is either going to be very interesting or...no, it’s going to be very interesting. But it’ll be either scandalous or dangerous.*

One look at the [Hunter] and she nodded slowly.

“I don’t see why not. Father is always asking me to do what I can for our cousins...by all means. Ask a Thronebearer for anything you need, and don’t worry about the favor.”

She stepped back, and Ser Dalimont moved forwards with a bow.

“I shall escort you to a secured room, Your Highness. May I offer refreshments?”

—

Seraphel practically *ran* upstairs, where she shut herself in her room, then turned.

“Tell me we can listen in.”

Dalimont smiled.

“We can listen in, Your Highness. The question is—do we? A Duchess and Princess of Samal may object—at length—if we betray their trust.”

Telleis had come to Seraphel because she knew that short of Noelictus’ own palace and spymasters, which they doubtless had, there was only one group who were able to ensure absolute secrecy even in a foreign land.

That was Calanfer’s diplomats, Thronebearers. She’d asked Seraphel for a favor, and the [Princess] could oblige.

But Seraphel wanted to know what Telleis was talking about with that [Hunter]. She had a hunch it mattered—and with respect to Telleis, Seraphel was not above spying on her guests.

“What are the odds they can tell we’re spying?”

“Tell? Remote, unless any of the four are actually [Rogues]. Guess? They likely suspect we know, but they must be desperate to talk in privacy.”

“...And Calanfer is famous for hoarding secrets and favors. They *must* be talking about something they’re afraid of saying if Noelictus’ agents could pick up on it. I have to know. Dalimont, get me ears.”

Seraphel made up her mind at once. Dalimont didn’t have anything as silly as a listening spell, but to listen into a part of the house, he had a thin tube of metal, which he had apparently inserted into the wall. It looped through the walls of the mansion and into an odd device on the other end. It was enchanted to make any sounds louder, so it magnified the conversation in the room.

Seraphel listened as he took notes. They were very silent, although the listening-device only worked one-way.

“...I’ll need to make it up to Calanfer somehow. There’s always a favor with the King of Diplomacy and his get.”

Telleis was speaking as she set up some privacy spells in the room. Sadly, that was basic and didn't work on physical devices that were already there. No wonder she'd come to experts. Seraphel felt bad about betraying her trust...but only a bit. Telleis clearly knew the score, and Greina replied with a chuckle.

"I rather like her. Seraphel's more down-to-earth than I expected, and she helped the folk of Afiele, from what I've heard. But now we have a private place. Unless the Thronebearers are spying on us?"

Seraphel turned red at the compliment, and Dalimont winced.

"We're gaining a reputation His Majesty would rather we not have."

"Well, it's clearly accurate. *Shut up.*"

Seraphel listened to the group introducing themselves to the strange [Hunter]. Her name was 'Haeight', apparently, and she was...a childhood friend of Greina's?

This was all basic stuff, and Seraphel almost thought this was going to be something lower on the scandalous scale. Like a love affair between Haeight and Greina or the Gold-rank adventurers were hiring her to do their work for them.

...As it turned out, it was more than Seraphel could imagine. Her mouth slowly opened wider and wider as she heard Haeight and Greina discussing...

"*A conspiracy in the Hunter's Guild?*"

Dalimont looked alarmed as Neranthei joined him in taking frantic notes. That was what was being implied! The two were discussing the Hunter's Guild's system of indulgences, and it was worse than anything Seraphel could have imagined.

The Veteran Hunters just sat around all day and did nothing? Hunters like Haeight were being worked to death? But the really damning stuff came

from Greina.

Fiskren's daughter, a *Duke's* daughter, had this to say of the royal family and court:

"I still feel like Agshiga's a hero, Haeight. I want to believe it. But I never saw her kill an undead, not once. Even if she's married into the royal family, she's part of the *Deathhunt*—and the royal family is corrupt. Princess Kadane is no fit heir and would rather dance away than do her job. However, Prince Seratoito's either a traitor or corrupt, or both."

A traitor? Seraphel's suspicions of the man were becoming reality rapidly, and the [Huntress] was in on...

She looked at Dalimont, and he glanced up.

"Do we tell His Majesty, Highness?"

She bit her lip and wondered what her father would do with this knowledge.

"He might throw Noelictus to the wolves. Culin and Sasi—oh dead gods. Tell him, and confirm this without alerting Noelictus' crown. *This is insane.*"

A new picture of Noelictus was emerging for Seraphel. It was this:

King Nicte Alloreve was not a bad man. Or, rather, morality had little to do with it. The result was the same.

The Hunter's Guild was corrupted. They were funded, overfunded by the crown, and worked their new recruits down to exhaustion. The Veteran Hunters were fat off of excess funds, and their inaction was creating a huge division within the Guild—

And the Landsreight. The nobility weren't blind. Both good men like Fiskren and self-serving ones like Seelthru could tell that the Guild wasn't working optimally. However, that led to a split where one half was trying to

pull back power from the crown to better address the wasteful spending—and the other half wanted it for themselves.

In the middle of this was the issue of Seratoito, Kadane, and the absent Queen Cathiel Nicterise. Seratoito was forming a rival powerbase by courting the less-than-loyal [Lords], and he might be complicit in the Guild's financial corruption or just content to spend on them for their loyalty.

All the while, Ovela and border-provinces suffered undead attacks without Guild support or soldiers. Oh, and King Alloreve might be literally cheating on his wife with a giant spider.

When Seraphel delivered that in a report to her father, he was silent for a long time.

"...I knew about the spider allegations. Nicte's always denied it in private, you know, but Princess Kadane has to wear illusions when she goes out. As to Cathiel, she's a troubled woman. He's not keeping her confined nor is it just marital strife...though that may play into it."

"Father! Is that all you have to say?"

She practically shrieked at him. Reclis was silent, but a sharp voice cut in.

"Seraphel, control yourself."

Her mother, Ielane, made Seraphel freeze up. Reclis murmured.

"Leave Seraphel, Ielane, she's had a very stressful time in Afiele and now this. It can't be fun thinking you're marrying into a sinking ship."

"She is a [Princess] of Calanfer. I should have sent Vensha with her instead of Dalimont."

Seraphel was glad she hadn't. Vensha was one of the most senior Thronebearers who served Ielane directly, and she scared Seraphel almost as much as her mother. Reclis rejoined the conversation.

“It’s a bad look. I was aware of a lot of this, but hearing it from Duchess Greina...I’d almost suspect a plot against Nichte, because this is too convenient. But Samal’s [Princess] being in it—they don’t take sides politically. It squares with what I’ve heard. Well, Seraphel, I will be listening hard for any treasonous plots by Seratoito. It takes time for nobility to work up the nerve—and means—to rebel. As for the corruption, Noelictus still has an army. If they’re invaded, maybe the Hunter’s Guild will act or schism. Either way, it’s a dam bursting, and if the nation survives, they will be stronger for it. What a shame, I thought Nichte was better than this.”

He sounded disappointed, not upset! Seraphel was trying to breathe.

“Father, Ailendamus is invading!”

“And invasions are difficult. Are you worried we’ll make you stay on the front? I doubt your husband will be so foolish, but I will make sure you don’t stay in Ovela, Seraphel. You’ll be safe; even if war comes to Menorome, you are a [Princess] of Calanfer, a third party. Dead gods damn it, though. I was hoping Noelictus would be a strong ally against Ailendamus, and they’re far, far worse off than I expected. Listen, Seraphel. I know you don’t like the corruption and inefficiency in the way Noelictus runs. I hate it myself, but there is little you can do. Focus on Ovela. If Ovela stands, and we get an Earl out of Fallien or Piral, they may be a strong enough leader to challenge Nichte. The Landsreight produces a reform, and the Hunter’s Guild is revealed to be corrupt. It’ll be messy, but we can fix up Noelictus in a decade.”

“So long as the nation is standing.”

Ielane’s voice was less reassuring. Seraphel just sat there, and she focused on something Reclis had said. She knew she was his instrument in Noelictus, but...

“Fallien or Piral? I thought my marriage to him was to make him the Earl of Ovela.”

Reclis paused.

“Ah, well, I was going to tell you this later, Seraphel. Your marriage is going to destabilize their arguments over succession. Twins. So messy with inheritance, and their father refused to pick. Anyways. Once you’re married to Lord Fallien, I want you to assess their personalities, ability to lead—and choose. The best Earl should lead Ovela. And you will be placed to make that happen.”

...Her? Seraphel might be told to sabotage...

“What about Noelictus, Father?”

“If it runs, it runs. We’re not in the business of reforming nations wholesale, Seraphel. I am focused on Ailendamus. It is coming after Noelictus, and we are on the chopping block if...no. Nevermind. Focus on Ovela. You’re bound there soon enough. I’m told the Twins have stopped the Baron before he even got to the keep, so I’ve ordered a quick wedding. Head there, head back unless Lord Fallien thinks it’s safe. Thank you for being so diligent. Ielane, do you have anything to say?”

“Polish your acting skills, Seraphel. He should at least believe you like him a little. Most men can be satisfied with that.”

Then the call ended.

Her final court visit to the Court of Dusk was the disaster. It went well enough at first.

“You’re bound to Ovela? I shall send you with an escort of our [Soldiers]. The Twins have halted the Baron, but he’s building fortifications—no, I won’t bore you with the strategy. Your Highness, you have been entirely too gracious to our dysfunctional family.”

King Alloreve smiled from his throne, but he couldn’t disguise a slight strain tonight. *Because of the war? Because he was corrupt?*

Seraphel hid this all behind a smile. It was an actual banquet tonight, and there was entertainment, dancing—

“I hope to return with Lord Fallien to the courts at times.”

“I should like that. If you should return to Menorome, my palace is open to you.”

He met her eyes, and her heart hurt because she thought he meant it. Then the [King] glanced over towards the stairs that led to the back of the palace. A woman—Keeper Liletrec—had stopped halfway down.

“Excuse me. Please, enjoy the banquet.”

He stepped off his throne and strode up the stairs where he talked with the [Keeper]. As Seraphel turned, her [Long Ear] caught a few words Liletrec whispered.

“—*very poorly. Her season—*”

“*Keep her from the guests if you can.*”

That was Allore’s reply. Was it about the [Queen]? Seraphel walked back to the Court of Dusk, and Princess Kadane was drinking.

“Seraphel! You can’t leave me! Cursed [Princesses] should stay together! I order you to stay. What’s the point of you going to Ovela, anyways? To watch idiots hack each other up?”

“I’m sorry, Kadane, I have to be wed.”

The spider-[Princess] lying back on her reclining couch fixed Seraphel with a side-eye.

“And you look so happy to do it.”

“I’m content.”

That was the best Seraphel could manage. Kadane twitched her cup, then desisted.

“What a difference you and I are. You’re willing to shit upon idiots, but you’ll still get married for your nation. I would rather die.”

“I suppose. I want to go to Ovela, anyways. The young [Lord] and [Lady] in Afiele need someone to keep an eye on them.”

“Oh, those children.”

Kadane lost her thirst abruptly and put the cup down.

“That old battleaxe, Grishen, is taking care of them? I hate her. Nice of you to go there to check on them. Fine! But when you come back, I’ll drag you across Menorome. In the *meantime*—let’s have some fun!”

With that, Seraphel and she were up and circulating with the nobility. Spiders or not, it was far more festive in the Court of Dusk—mostly because the wine was flowing free and there was entertainment.

Fresh illusions from Wistram! Tales of the King of Destruction’s return performed in verse by [Bards]—it was not all just wondrous. Seraphel felt a chill when they described the King of Destruction returning to war, his capital city spitting lightning bolts down on the army trying to return him to slumber for good.

King Nichte was far better at putting on a show for his nobles and guests than the Synphasia, possibly because he had hired more wide-ranging entertainments. The food was good, and Seraphel was delighted to learn that a mishap had resulted in the best of all things.

“For your entertainment tonight, I regret, dear guests, that the esteemed Rolare the Violinist could not attend.”

Keeper Liletrec made the announcement after the [Bards], and there were several resigned groans. Prince Seratoito remarked loudly to his wife.

“That half-Elf seems to play one in ten times. I *hope* we find some new performer, because I am getting tired of *not* hearing him.”

Even Kadane agreed with her brother. She stomped a foot.

“Wonderful! The night’s entertainment, ruined. I need to find a barrel, Seraphel. I even thought Mother might listen to him—she will be even worse after this.”

She filled up two goblets and took them down so fast Seraphel winced.

“Is—everything alright with Her Majesty?”

“*Guess, idiot.*”

Kadane relented when she saw Seraphel’s face.

“Sorry. No, she is not. She’s in a ‘bad season’ as we’d tell the common folk, and that’s why you haven’t seen her. I do, though, and if that half-Elf would stop wiping his behind for five seconds, perhaps—”

She stopped as Keeper Liletrec went on. Seraphel’s heart leapt as the dry voice continued.

“—However, it seems we have a replacement. From the Synphasia, I present a ‘rising star’. Insofar as the Court of Dusk enjoys light. The [Singer], Cara. To perform for us all. Applaud if you wish.”

Then she vanished, and Seraphel began to smile. Kadane turned her head suspiciously.

“Now there’s a thing I’ve never seen. And here I thought you were as miserable as me. Stop it. Do you know this woman?”

“She’s...a friend. You’ll enjoy this.”

Heads turned, and a pink-haired young woman strode forwards, smiling as she saw Seraphel. Cara O’Sullivan stood there and spoke.

“Ladies and gentlemen. Thank you for having me. For my first song, I would like to sing something Noelictus has never heard before.”

It was a bold claim, and the Court of Dusk faced Cara skeptically. But Seraphel didn’t doubt for a second. She saw Cara lift a strange object, a carved piece of wood, rounded at the top and with a grey base.

Was it meant to magnify her voice? It certainly seemed that way. Cara closed her eyes—

And she began to sing songs such as Seraphel had never heard before. As ever, as always.

Some of the songs Seraphel knew. Cara played the best songs, from the one she had sung with Violetta in Afiele’s keep for the first time to the other ones in the Synphasia.

Each time, she sang with an odd accompaniment, instruments that no one had heard before playing in the air. It was either a Skill or something else.

Of course it took the nobility by storm. The music was unique, the *style* was unique. Kadane stopped drinking and listened, so fascinated for the first few songs that she only turned to Seraphel during one of the applause breaks.

“She’s like nothing I’ve heard! What kind of music is that?”

Both knew the various styles, but Seraphel’s only answer came from Cara.

“I believe it’s called—‘pop’.”

“What a stupid name. I love it.”

It was such a silly and strange thing to inflate with pride over someone else’s achievements, and Seraphel wished to bottle the emotion for a worse day.

—Which might be tomorrow as she left the city and the odd community she'd attained. Kadane, Cara, and even the odd Court of Dusk were not the worst places to be.

But Ovela and her marriage to Lord Fallien awaited. That made Seraphel well and truly tired and reminded her of her duties to Calanfer's crown.

First the wedding night. Then we'll see.

Bleak thoughts, but Culin and Sasi made her willing to go—otherwise come midnight, she might have been as soused as Kadane was already and have to be bundled into the carriage by her [Maids].

Speaking of which, Thistel seemed most reluctant to leave. She was gossiping with some of the castle's cobwebbed staff. Mariel, by contrast, would be happy to go *right now*. She still hadn't gotten over the spiders.

"Two [Maids] will be a poor company for Ovela. Does Calanfer recruit from the local populace or do they ship your servants out for you?"

Kadane murmured. Seraphel sighed.

"Mariel and Thistel would help train anyone up to standard. My mother doesn't often send more than one or two and hopes that the locals will be enough for me. Ovela does have a royal staff."

"Hm. More like battlefield veterans who can cook and clean."

Seraphel shuddered as Cara's next song ended and she was given another round of applause. Then King Nicte beckoned from his throne. It seemed he'd returned, and he gave Cara a wan smile.

"*Most* entertaining. Let the [Singer] advance. I should like words with her. Miss Cara, have you any songs for me?"

Seraphel was slightly apprehensive as she saw her friend advance, because Cara had made it well known how she felt about royalty before. But it seemed she was on her best behavior, and Seraphel returned to the issues of staffing.

“It certainly sounds that if I stay for any period of time at all—and I do believe my father hopes I will be out of danger—I should be prepared for strife. My husband to be, Lord Fallien, may wish me to be by his side.”

Kadane’s mouth twisted, and she spat some of the wine back in the goblet. She gave Seraphel a sideways look and sighed.

“Yes...Fallien who’ve I’ve heard so much about. He does come to the Landsreight to curry favor, you know. Who often talks about you. That’s sarcasm, by the way. It was funnier to imagine some annoying Calanferian. Less funny to think you’ll be miserable with him.”

Seraphel’s heart sank further, but Kadane was honest, brutally so.

“Do you think he thinks of my curse...?”

“No, I think he’s just at odds with his sister. And if there was any woman for him to marry, it would be her given she’s the name most often said from his lips. *That* would solve Ovela’s issues, eh?”

Oh, Noelictus humor was very odd. Seraphel heard Cara strike up a new song and saw Nichte smiling upon his throne. Then it occurred to her this was her *last* chance.

Perhaps she didn’t have to go alone. If anything would help Culin or Sasi—Seraphel took a breath. She had not pushed hard, but perhaps now was a good moment.

“Kadane, do you think you could prevail on your father to give me more than a royal escort?”

“Oh, for you I could see about a few more soldiers. I’ll try to get his ear once that song ends.”

The [Princess] was willing to do that at once, but Seraphel was thinking more...dramatically. That Baron Digneral worried her father. He was high-level, and apparently those Drell Knights were a force far beyond most Thronebearer’s capabilities. There was even a ‘Great Knight’ candidate,

some Mirror-Knight who could literally *bounce* [Fireballs] and even volleys of arrows back at those who fired at him.

“I was thinking something more dramatic, Kadane. A show of force. Would you be willing to...send me Veteran Hunters? Even three? They needn’t fight, but it might show the Landsreight *and* Ovela that the crown is giving full support to the war. Why, if even Agshiga were to tour the walls a bit, that might give Ailendamus pause.”

Given how lazy they were, she thought her offer more than fair. If a [Princess] was safe, Agshiga, a royal consort and far more capable in battle, should be safe as could be.

However, Kadane’s expression went extremely blank, then guarded before she gave Seraphel a laugh.

“Dead gods, you do ask a lot, Seraphel. Let me see. Hunter’s Guild? No. But I could send a hundred more bows to Ovela. How’s that? But no [Hunters]. They’re all busy, and Father would throw a fit.”

Now that was strange. Dalimont half-turned his head as he pretended to watch Cara, and Seraphel knew she was thinking the same thing as he.

Why so resistant? This wasn’t hard, but Kadane was suddenly nervous. Seraphel pressed more.

“Come now, Kadane. They won’t be in harm’s range.”

“They’re busy. Seraphel, don’t argue on that, please. I’d hate to practice my wine-tossing Skills, and I haven’t had the urge so far.”

Kadane was getting vexed. Yet at this point, Seraphel’s niceness was starting to turn to annoyance. It was one thing to like the somewhat indolent royal family, but Afiele was in danger.

“It’s not as if you’re going, Kadane. *Three* Veteran Hunters? You have hundreds. Let’s be real, I would send three Thronebearers in an instant if my friend asked.”

“Ooh, Seraphel the Sharptongued strikes. You’re wounding me.”

Kadana avoided Seraphel’s gaze. She seemed guilty, but then glared.

“Look, take it up with Guildmistress Deilfec.”

That woman was apparently often at court, but Seraphel hadn’t seen her, and to hear even the Marquis and other nobles talk of her—she was a scary woman. Seraphel raised her brows and voice.

“Kadane, you are *royalty*. If you give the order—”

Kadane hissed at her suddenly, an outburst of sudden emotion.

“Would you drop it? Please?”

Seraphel hesitated. This seemed genuine, and Kadane was no good disassembler. She bit her lip and whispered back.

“I’m sorry, Kadane. I have to push. Afiele is filled with people dear to me.”

“Well then, good luck. Because I can’t help you. Sorry.”

The [Princess] didn’t bother engaging with Seraphel. Rather cleverly, she *bit* the goblet with her spider mandibles and, using it like a face-cover, strode past Seraphel. She used her hands to fill up her plate and then headed for her favorite couch.

“So *that’s* how you use spider-fangs.”

Dalimont muttered. Seraphel stepped on his foot.

“Dalimont! I’m trying to get help or at least one [Hunter].”

“It seems rather unlikely.”

He pointed out, and Seraphel glowered at him.

“Maybe from Kadane or King Allore, but as we’ve observed, the Landsreight has the power to force the crown’s hand. So observe. Let’s serve them some...Calanferian diplomacy.”

He smiled and nodded.

“I can at least stop the [King]’s hangers-on. Who shall you engage?”

“Find me Seratoito and Agshiga. They’re the weak spot, and get me a scene.”

Seraphel cracked her knuckles. If Kadane wouldn’t play nice, then she’d see what Seraphel the Sharptongued could do when she chose to exercise her class and training.

Calanferian diplomacy got used as a joke by other nations, but that was because they thought it was brown-nosing and over-civility. What it was really like was twisting someone’s arm—but with words, rather than a sword in hand. It was the same, but the sword was invisible and intangible. But it cut just as well. Blackmail was a weapon as sharp as could be.

Prince Seratoito was ‘showing off’ his consort, Agshiga, by having her toss daggers into a few targets set up as everyone listened to Cara’s songs. She was protesting, but she could hit a target forty paces away without looking at it.

Perfect. Dalimont located them, then gave Seraphel a run-up as Dame Neranthei and her [Maids] approached.

Kadane tried to stop her, or perhaps King Nicte did. A suddenly *very interested* member of the court strode over to ask Seraphel whether or not she’d care to...?

“Oh dear me! I’m so terribly sorry!”

Ser Dalimont turned with a tray of food in hand for his [Princess] and spilled it all over the courtier. He patted the spluttering man first as people

laughed at the silly Thronebearer. And when someone else tried to hurry over to Seraphel, Ser Dalimont's attempts to clean up the man had him trip.

Dogpile. Seraphel was coincidentally just in front of the commotion and Cara's song was at a lull! *Showtime*, as her friend would say.

"Prince Seratoito, would you perchance care to offer me a small boon? I have quite enjoyed Menorome's hospitality, but I have an engagement in Ovela, and I think you are the man to do me a favor. Or Calanfer if not me. A word, Your Highness?"

He turned, wineglass in hand, smile on his face, and he looked puzzled at first, then gave her a huge grin.

"For a [Princess]? I do like my favors."

Marquis Seelthru looked pleased that Seraphel was favoring 'his' faction, and Duke Fiskren scowled faintly until Seraphel met Seratoito's gaze. Kadane's eyes were burning in the back of her head, and King Nicte was glancing up from his throne. Perhaps they sensed her over-loud voice and could tell she was making a play.

Too late. Seraphel spoke.

"Would you care to send your consort—or join me as I head to Ovela? I *am* worried about this warfront even though the dashing Twins of Ovela are checking this [Baron] of Ailendamus. But checking hardly sounds like defeating, and a few of the *splendid* [Hunters] of Noelictus might well help drive them back to their rightful homes. They needn't even shoot any arrows or crossbows; one fancies that they'd be a deterrent. Would three Veteran Hunters, say, help me make a show and impress my husband-to-be as I reach his home?"

A murmur swept the courts, and Agshiga's head turned, not so much in alarm as with an odd frown. *Was she afraid of going to war?* Again, Seraphel was reminded of Dalimont's claims she was good at fighting—and Haeight's confession that the Veteran Hunters were lazy one and all.

She expected Seratoito to lend his wife out, or at least a Veteran Hunter or two, because he of all the royal family seemed least attached to loyalty. But he gave her an odd frown, then a smile.

“Your Highness, I cannot part ways with my consort, and as for Veteran Hunters—that’s my father’s domain, or so I fear. It’s a splendid notion.”

“More than splendid! A Veteran Hunter or two? I’ve heard that Ovela is prey to saboteurs. It’d be something to have those [Rogues] run into a *real* predator of Noelictus. What a splendid idea, Your Highness Seraphel! Hear, hear!”

Marquis Seelthru was all over the idea, and Seratoito was not. *So odd!* Seraphel raised her brows as the [Prince] frowned. He’d just claimed it was out of his domain, but for an arrogant [Prince], she would have expected him to force the issue even if it was...

Well, at any rate, the motion was gaining steam, and the Landsreight’s complaints returned five-fold now Seraphel had put it into the air.

“Three Veteran Hunters to escort the Princess of Calanfer to Ovela. It has a nice ring.”

Duke Fiskren approached, bowing, and again, Marquis Seelthru and he stood united. *What an odd issue to unite both loyal and self-serving men around the same cause*—and Seraphel’s frown deepened as she heard Seratoito coughing.

“Oh, Duke Fiskren, I should have known you’d make a play.”

“Hardly a play. It’s what the Landsreight has been pushing—more support for Ovela in this conflict.”

“Ah, but then where would it end? Fiskren’s Hunter’s Guild is quite large, and if we made a habit of giving you every excuse to order a [Hunter] around...you may not know this, Princess, but they are actually able to ignore even the Landsreight to execute their duties. In service *only* to the crown.”

He twisted it quite well, given the circumstances! Marquis Seelthru gave Duke Fiskren such a suspicious look that Seraphel swore that Seratoito had used a Skill. The Duke immediately began denying he had any such goals, which of course just prompted speculation.

Was he that resistant to the idea too? Kadane, Seratoito—Seraphel decided to get unpleasant.

“Well, I may be an outsider, Prince Seratoito, but it seems to me that your [Hunters] are like our [Knights]. Is this fair at least when it comes to defending Noelictus?”

“It may be.”

He allowed, but his eyes were wary, and he knew he had to agree to Seraphel’s easy statement—but he winced despite himself. Seraphel’s next words proved the gesture was premature, but accurate.

“Well, our loyal Thronebearers do bleed and die in both war *and* fighting monsters and brigands. I am not one to question Noelictus, but when, exactly, would the [Hunters] be mobilized? When an army crosses your borders? Or do they abstain from war altogether?”

“That’s—true. They would fight in a war, absolutely.”

Duke Fiskren looked relieved and touched his mustache, and Marquis Selethru agreed.

“If war were to threaten the land itself, every hand would go to war.”

“Well, is it a word or an act? Because Ailendamus is *in* Noelictus, and sons and daughters lie dead. Three Veteran Hunters, Prince. Just three? Calanfer will match that gesture at least, with its Thronebearers. And with me!”

She actually thought the egotistical prince gave her a nod for a second. Which was ridiculous because she didn’t think he was intelligent enough to see...well, even if you didn’t appreciate Seraphel’s full attack, you could get parts of it.

She was appealing on multiple grounds: law, public sentiment, and even her own nation's pride. It was getting difficult to disagree.

"...Perhaps I could go? For a week or two, my [Prince]? It would be easiest for me."

Agshiga interrupted, and Seratoito pursed his lips.

"Argh, that's the trouble with a dutiful wife. Too eager to please!"

He threw back his head and laughed as she blushed, and then he gave Seraphel a shrug.

"Agshiga is an army. Perhaps her and some rookie [Hunters]? That may serve."

"What about a smaller detachment? Twenty Veteran Hunters and the Deathhunt's Commander—nay, what about the entire Royal Deathhunt? Put the *fear* of Noelictus into them, Your Highness!"

The Marquis was getting eager, and Seratoito held out a hand.

"Hold on, Marquis. Hold on, man! My wife and the Deathhunt are too valuable to get killed fighting Ailendamus' grunts."

"Three, then?"

"I'm more keen to send just Agshiga—ah, but here comes a spoilsport. Father, have you heard Princess Seraphel's unique plan?"

His Majesty himself had arrived, and Seraphel turned with a smile, ready to fight. King Nichte just sighed and gave her a nod.

"Calanfer does love to suggest. I should have known Reclis' daughter would weigh in on matters of state. Your Highness—we have given Ovela plenty of aid. Our [Hunters] are busy, and I am loathe to waste their abilities."

It was the most direct rebuke she had ever heard from him, and she feared she'd gained his ire, but Seraphel had to stay the course. She bowed deeply.

"I regret that I am so presumptuous, Your Majesty, but would it hurt to experiment and send some [Hunters] to see if they make a great splash? An entire province is at stake!"

And why are you fighting so hard to keep just a handful of Veteran Hunters here? Corruption? There had to be more, but Seraphel had no time to dig. She had the bit in her teeth, and she was pushing hard.

King Alloreve was trying to turn this back on her as Calanferian interference, but the problem was that his nobles agreed. Duke Fiskren lifted his cup.

"Your Majesty, we could put it to a vote."

"Over some [Hunters]? I don't think the Landsreight wants to convene..."

A murmur made King Nicte pause and then sigh. Checkmate. Seraphel's smile was wide, and she did offer him a way to save face. There was nothing like a vengeful [King] and wounded pride. Alloreve was a genial sort, so she had been ready to risk it—but she fluttered her hands and her eyelashes.

"I would *hate* to make this a formal vote, Duke Fiskren. If Prince Seratoito would accede, I am sure Huntress-Commander Agshiga and three Veteran Hunters would make Ailendamus sweat!"

"Agreed! Perhaps they could take a shot at that Mirror Knight. Your Majesty, this is all very reasonable, and I would vote it is the barest measure we can ask for. Will you not accede?"

The nobles had Seraphel's back, and King Nicte Alloreve sighed.

"I do agree. Three Veteran Hunters and Agshiga. Your Highness, you do fight for Ovela. Valiantly."

Seraphel's smile was wide and relieved. She missed the warning signs: Princess Kadane turning and swearing and striding over, a rustle in the webs

above, and the court falling silent.

“I am simply concerned about my husband-to-be, and I confess, Afiele. It seems to me the [Hunters] will be a splendid message, Your Majesty—”

Then a hand landed on her shoulder, and someone spoke.

“Who is it? Who is sending my Hunters? Who is causing trouble? I thought it was a [Violinist], not those annoying upbeat songs. *Three?*”

Then it felt like a tempest stood behind Seraphel, a whirlwind of darkness incarnate. At first, Seraphel thought someone had opened a window and it was a storm outside, but then she realized—it was an *aura*.

Her eyes opened wide. She felt a large hand and turned—and there stood a woman who was nearly seven feet high. Tall, so gaunt you could see her cheekbones, and imperious. Eyes wide, hair the color of Keeper Liletrec’s dress as the [Royal Keeper] strode after her—and fearsome.

Queen Cathiel Nicterise looked like she had woken up on the wrong side of bed. And then not slept a wink for the last hundred days. Her eyes were bloodshot, and her expression thunderous.

“Your Majesty! Greetings after so long!”

Duke Fiskren and the court instantly bowed. Queen Nicterise’s glare blew across them, and some shivered. Whether they were afraid or not was hard to say; *Seraphel* was terrified, not least because she felt the woman’s ire from her aura.

But that hand was terrifyingly strong, and the [Queen] was staring at her with eyes that burned like pale yellow flames. Her dress was coal-black, and she spoke slowly.

“Nicté. Seratoito. Have you lost your senses? The Hunters being sent to war? It’s a skirmish, you said.”

“My love—”

Nicte stepped forwards, and she spat at him. *Spat at him.*

“I am not in love with you right now. I am *wroth*, and I demand *answers!* Why are you two acting like fools, and *who is this?* Kadane, get over here!”

She was angry, and everyone not in immediate range of her immediately pretended she was not half-screaming towards the royal family. Nicte halted, hand outstretched, and someone muttered as Seraphel heard it—

“—*a bad season yet. That poor [Princess]—*”

The hand was so tight that only when Thistel, Mariel, and the Thronebearers bowed did Queen Cathiel let go. Dalimont was there, and he checked Seraphel’s shoulder—but Nicterise had those masked bodyguards and an entourage of dozens.

There was no question that *she* was the power when she was present, but one look at her face said why King Nicte sat on the throne most of the time; she was not the woman who would do well with the Landsreight or matters of state.

Yet Queen Cathiel *did* acknowledge Duke Fiskren and even said something odd. She gave him one sharp nod, and her eyes and nostrils flared.

“Duke Fiskren. I should like to throw you off the balcony’s edge. But *thank you*, and I shall doubtless apologize once I am in a better mood. For now, keep your civilities and mouth out of my ears.”

He bowed silently, and Seraphel gulped. That was a [Duke] of the realm, and if he were not so reasonable—the Marquis looked sourly downwards. She understood more of why dissent reared its head.

But then Queen Cathiel looked at her. She bent over, eyed Seraphel’s hair, and spat more words like venom.

“*Princess of Calanfer.* King Reclis’ daughter and Ielane’s mark all over you. No wonder you have such smart ideas. She always did get the thought that she knew what was best for everyone into her head. You want my

Hunters? You, marrying one of the Twins? Who are you, and how dare you order my folk around in my stead?”

Seraphel did her best. She bowed her head low and sincerely, lower than she needed to, as she curtsied just as deeply.

“Your Majesty, I am Princess Seraphel du Marquin in service to the Eternal Throne of Calanfer, 4th Princess, and I do humbly beg your pardon for any mistakes—I was simply speaking of the war and asking for an escort—”

Cathiel stared at her, and her expression darkened still. She passed a hand over her face.

“I am not in the mood for this. Calanfer. You *do not order around the Hunter’s Guild*. Nor do you, my Landsreight, *need* the [Hunters] now. Send a thousand [Soldiers] in their stead!”

She snapped at Duke Fiskren, who bowed silently.

“As Her Majesty wills it.”

“As I will it? I have made it *abundantly clear*—no, a foreigner comes to court for one week and has the gall to give orders. To Agshiga no less, a royal consort of the throne! *You*. Your pretty request is denied. And I have half a mind to tell Reclis and Ielane to keep their daughter and people out of my court for the rest of time!”

Her voice had already been at a shout, but it became thunderous now. Dalimont swallowed. What an issue that would be! Even if temporary—Nicte stepped forwards.

“My love, that would be egregious.”

“*Would it?* Then I am so very glad you are telling me because I don’t *feel* like it is. But I am also inclined to bar that [Princess] from the Court of Dusk and the Palace of Shadows for a year! Liletrec, is that appropriate?”

The [Royal Keeper] bowed silently, and Seraphel gulped. But to her relief, the masked woman simply shook her head.

“Egregious, Your Majesty. She is merely slightly offensive.”

Cathiel calmed slightly, but she was still angry and pacing now. She turned to Liletrec.

“This is why I need you. No one else will give me frank truths. Very well. I am going now. You—*Your Highness of Calanfer*. No Hunters. No games. I thought you were a pleasant woman from Kadane’s babble of you, but it is abundantly clear you are another Calanferian snake.”

Seraphel was beet red and at the center of attention. Nevermind that Queen Cathiel was being excessively harsh and she was getting sympathy—more than one person like Lady Rizetine was glaring at Seraphel, and she couldn’t remember being publicly embarrassed like this. Even her sisters’ pranks like a dress that fell apart in court was nothing compared to being shouted at by a [Queen].

Kadane looked appalled as Cathiel turned.

“Mother, go back to your rooms. You’ve shouted at her enough.”

“Have I?”

Nicterise rounded on Kadane, and the [Princess] flinched. Cathiel stared at her—and then Liletrec took her arm.

“Your Majesty should go.”

“Very well.”

Cathiel was breathing hard, but she did turn. She was about to go when Seraphel, angry, distraught, and seeing all the help she had just secured for Ovela go up in flames because of this—damned woman who shouted at her own daughter, snapped.

Seraphel the Sharptongued. She didn’t use a Skill, but she did speak, and Dalimont’s hand was a second too late in stopping her.

“Your Majesty, I may be a poor, interfering busybody from pushy Calanfer, but at least I saw Afiele’s plight and Ovela’s now! Do you know Lord Lantal and Lady Risel Afiele? *They are dead when a few Hunters would have made all the difference!* If not for me, think of—”

Too late. Dalimont cut her off, and Cathiel stopped. Nicte grabbed her arm, and so did Liletrec. They actually tried to pull her away—but it was too late. Cathiel turned into a statue, but one made of corded muscle.

“*Do I know...*”

“My love, breathe. Don’t turn around. You, bring Her Highness away. Now.”

The [King]’s words weren’t needed. The Calanfer escort was hurrying Seraphel away fast as could be, Ser Dalimont and the [Maids] practically carrying Seraphel as they dragged her across the floor. But Cathiel was muttering.

“Risel? Do I know—*Risel?* I adored her. Where were my Hunters?”

“Cathiel, don’t—”

She turned and was on Seraphel so fast that the [Princess] screamed. Ser Dalimont tried to get in the way. Nicterise *shoved* him so hard he went skidding across the ground.

She was insanely strong! And when she grabbed Seraphel’s arm, the [Princess] gasped and went white. Her bones were being ground together. She looked up at Cathiel’s blazing eyes, and the [Queen] unloaded upon her.

“*I should like to murder you.* Against my instincts. Against *all* of diplomacy and the fact that I know you are an ignorant chit of a girl who thinks she understands everything, I would like to hurt you. But I shall content myself by saying that you are a worthless woman and Calanfer is filled with scheming, traitorous cowards who know nothing of sacrifice. *Nothing of worth.*”

She was speaking while holding Seraphel's arm like a vise. So loudly that Seraphel knew everyone could hear, and the [Princess]' face drained of color. The [Queen]'s aura beat at her like rage incarnate.

“Your mother is a calculating bitch with ice colder than Cenidau, and she has raised over ten daughters and sons whom I would trust less than a pit of vipers. *You* disgust me. You are banned from the Court of Dusk. If I see you, I will call for an axe. I hope Ovela's marriage falls through that I might never hear your name spoken in my lands. And I can well see why no one lasted in marriage with you, from that Baron of Ailendamus all the way down to—”

She wasn't *stopping*. Seraphel was cowering now, overwhelmed by a hostile aura. King Nichte and the royal family were trying to pull the [Queen] away, the court was stone-faced—

And Cara tossed a cup of wine straight over Nictetise's back.

The [Queen] *jumped*, whirled, and five swords were at Cara's throat so fast that the [Singer] flinched and cut herself. But Nichte held up a hand.

“Bodyguards, stand down!”

The masked figures relaxed, and Agshiga lowered her blade. Cathiel's face had gone blank. She inspected the wine dripping down her back, as if it had reset her mood. Then she looked at Cara.

“Who is this?”

“The entertainment. Mother—”

Kadane was horrified. But Cathiel just pushed away a cloth wiping at her back. She turned back to Seraphel—but to even Seraphel's astonishment, her [Maid], Mariel, was blocking the way!

She was white-faced and doubtless aware what would happen if the [Queen] were to so much as slap her—but the [Maid] was protecting her mistress. Cathiel stared at Mariel, and Liletrec was in the way.

“Your Majesty—”

Cathiel inhaled once. Exhaled.

“I am not going to hit her, Liletrec. I am not that far gone with wrath. In fact, I quite respect that [Maid]. No, I take it back...”

Her eyes flickered. She looked at Seraphel, then turned to Cara.

“You. Do you have a reason for tossing wine on me?”

“Only that I’ve seen pigs worthier of wearing a crown. *How dare you shout at someone concerned for Afiele?* Do you even know what went on there?”

Cara. Seraphel closed her eyes. If she had made a mistake, she was still a [Princess], and Cathiel Nicterise would probably not have actually killed her; they would have stopped her from doing that to avoid a literal war. But Cara?

Nicte paled. The royal escort around the [Queen] grabbed at her as the court *gasped*. Several members drew blades there and then, but Cathiel’s face turned pale as a ghost—and then she spoke.

“I believe I need to step away before I cause an *incident*. Liletrec, take me back to my rooms.”

“At once, Your Majesty.”

Cathiel turned and, shaking with rage, strode after her [Royal Keeper] towards the stairs to the royal suites. Seraphel was frozen along with everyone else. Nicterise was halfway towards the stairs when she swung around. She pointed one finger at Cara.

“Execute her.”

Then she strode away. Cara froze as blades fell in around her throat.

“Damn—”

She looked at Seraphel as the [Princess] shook in the wake of her first meeting with Cathiel Nicterise. The one they called Noelictus' Queen of Faces. So far as Seraphel was concerned—Nicterise was the most terrifying [Queen] she had ever met.

They did not execute Cara. Seraphel was begging King Nicte in a rush when he finally got a word in.

“Your Highness! We are *not* going to behead your friend. She has insulted my wife, but we do not practice beheading for anything but treason.”

Seraphel finally inhaled for the first time in minutes.

“Your Majesty, I *beg* you leniency! Cara is a hothead, but she did it for me —”

“Yes. And what a fool she was. Even if it were not Noelictus and Cathiel were not in such a fury—I will take your request under advisement, but I do not gainsay my wife. She will be punished.”

“Not with death!”

“With service to the Hunter’s Guild of Noelictus! Which is not safe—but it is not a guaranteed death. I am wroth with Calanfer and myself and this entire evening, Your Highness. That is the best I offer you!”

King Nicte was angry. Seraphel gulped—then had the presence of mind to ask.

“Wait, why the Hunter’s Guild?”

The [King] rolled his eyes. He stood.

“I must check on Cathiel. *Ask anyone else.*”

He stormed out of the room, and Seraphel got a crash course on Noelictus law.

It was customary to offer prisoners and people who had committed crimes a choice. They could go to jail, pay fines, or face the [Huntsman]. Or—fight undead as a Conscripted Hunter.

It was often considered a death-sentence. Seraphel tore out of the palace, but when she tried to find Cara—she was already gone.

Apparently, the Hunter's Guild had processed her and made her a Conscript Hunter. They sent her to kill undead on the spot. Try as Dalimont might, they refused to tell him where she was, only that Seraphel would see Cara tomorrow.

If Cara survived. Seraphel would have gotten no rest that night, but the fallout from the court was overtaking her. She had to speak to her parents, who demanded to know what she had done to upset Queen Nicterise so much—and a [Hunter] was definitely *not* going to Ovela.

Several members of the Landsreight offered condolences. Seraphel paced and paced—and only got some sleep when Dame Neranthei offered her some tea. When she woke up and realized they'd drugged her, Seraphel was in a fury.

“Your Highness, you could do nothing for Cara in your sleep. Even if we found her, the Hunter's Guild is strict on interference, and Her Majesty is wroth with us.”

“If she is dead, I will make your life a hell, Dalimont.”

The Thronebearer didn't flinch in the face of the threat.

“Your Highness, remember who Cara is. She can survive undead slaying if anyone can.”

That was true. Seraphel calmed for a second, then got good news. Dame Neranthei skidded into the room.

“She’s alive. Your Highness—someone spotted her at the Hunter’s Guild. They’ll send her out in moments. We must go *now*—”

Seraphel shot to her feet.

“Then let’s go!”

She barely caught Cara as the young woman was marching out of the Hunter’s Guild in the company of nearly a dozen other [Hunters]. Including that familiar, white-haired [Hunter] that was Greina’s friend!

Seraphel was slightly relieved to see someone *competent* in charge—she had to assume Greina didn’t know poor [Hunters]. But she was filled with grief and guilt. No matter what she said, the Hunter, Haeight, refused to budge.

“Your Highness, under Noelictus’ laws, Miss Cara *is* a Conscript Hunter for a month. Freeing her would go against the crown—”

“This is insane! She was defending me! Cara, I am so sorry...Huntress, is there anyone I can speak to?”

“That would be Guildmistress Deilfec, if anyone. But I caution you, Your Highness—I cannot abandon my duties. Nor are you likely to succeed.”

Haeight pointed into the huge Hunter’s Guild, and Seraphel turned. *Maybe she could get Cara assigned to desk-duty?* A few strings pulled might help.

She squared her shoulders and nodded at Haeight.

“I shall! You—where are you going?”

“Killing undead. Seraphel, don’t get in more trouble. Really! That mad hatter of a [Queen]—”

Cara was furious, but she had survived one encounter with the dead already. Seraphel shushed her hurriedly and thought of what she could do. She couldn’t buy Cara gear or give her much of anything! At last, she snapped at Dalimont.

“Then at least a potion! No arguments!”

He handed over a healing potion, and Cara took it. She grasped Seraphel’s hand for a second.

“I’m okay, Seraphel. I can do this—it’s better than being executed on the spot. I really thought I’d get the old-fashioned monarch’s response to the uppity peasant there and then. Are *you* okay?”

“Queen Cathiel is angry at me, but I am leaving today. I will be fine, but Cara—”

“It’s okay. Just stay away from that place. And be safe in Ovela! Check on the kids.”

Yes, Culin and Sasi. Even so, a month of killing undead—Cara saw Seraphel’s anxiety and spoke.

“If you don’t get me on Desk Hunter duty—can you do me one favor, Seraphel? Please?”

“Yes. Anything.”

Seraphel pointed at the Synphasias as Hunter Haeight glared at them.

“Go to the Synphasias and get Elena from my rooms. Yoitha was probably taking care of her, or the manager has her doing chores, but keep her safe. You might need to pay her to keep her around, but *please*. She’s very important to me. She’s...from where I am.”

She whispered that, and Seraphel was confused. *Pay her?* She nodded.

“I will!”

Then Cara was marching off, and Seraphel turned to go to the Guildmaster and make sure her friend was safe.

She failed.

Guildmistress Deilfec was not seen at the Court of Dusk for the same reason Queen Cathiel wasn't: both were the most terrifying women that Seraphel had ever met.

And that included her mother. Cathiel was a tempest of fury.

Deilfec was a corpse.

She was a literal corpse. Her skin looked scarred on every line of her body. She had no hair, and her eyes either lacked eyelids or were popping out of her skull. They actually *hurt* when they rested on you.

"I do not answer to foreign royalty, Your Highness du Marquin. Nor does the Hunter's Guild have time to indulge your request."

"But for Calanfer—"

"No. If you persist in wasting my time, I will have you thrown out of my guild. If your friend lives, she will be freed in a month of all her crimes. There are no exceptions for Hunters. Now. Leave."

She brooked no argument, and Seraphel was afraid she *would* throw her out. She backed up, biting back curses. She tried one at the door, though.

"For a busy guild, you could spare at least one Hunter for Ovela!"

She actually *saw* the wood spark, and a black mark appeared as Deilfec looked up. The [Guildmistress] glared as Seraphel flinched and ducked back.

"Your friend will attest to how hard Hunters of Noelictus work. *For her sake*, you should hope the Veteran Hunters are putting down the dangerous undead. There are far worse monsters than zombies, and she will not survive meeting a Draugr."

Of course, that just left Seraphel depressed and scared—but she did know Cara had the power to defeat undead with her songs. But she had no

Dalius...

“It’s time to go to Ovela, Your Highness. I am sorry, but we will only drag Cara into further trouble if we try to help her, it seems. Should we find this friend of hers?”

“Yes, Dalimont. At least we can do *that*.”

Seraphel rested her head on the wood outside the Hunter’s Guild as a carriage pulled up for her. If there was one sunny spot this entire day—it was that Mariel was smiling.

“Your Highness, I’ve levelled up! And my class changed!”

Seraphel blinked. Of all the stupid—

No, well, Mariel *had* been very brave. And loyalty was rewarded with more than just Seraphel’s generosity. If she had time or had been able to rest for five minutes, she would have given Mariel a hefty bonus for her loyalty.

The world had beaten her to it.

“[Handmaiden of Honor]? *Oh, Mariel!*”

Thistel embraced her friend, and Mariel’s cheeks were red with embarrassed pride. Seraphel got into the carriage and stared at her.

“You deserve it, Mariel. You are incredibly brave to stand in front of Queen Cathiel. Mother may want you back in the palace after a bit.”

“I couldn’t do that. Your Highness, I—well, I just wanted to say that I like being in your service! A bit! And I have a new Skill for you. [Summon: Snackbox]!”

Mariel produced a box of treats, and Seraphel stared at it. She got free snacks.

The day was very strange. It got weirder when she found Cara’s ‘friend’ was none other than a Helpful Servant.

Helpful Servants were a growing trend in Terandria. They hadn't caught on in Ailendamus, a rich nation, but they were very popular, and even Calanfer had flirted with them.

"Queen Ielane doesn't approve of outside help that might report to someone else, but she admits they're second to our staff, Your Highness. They're hardworking, if a little strange. We debated hiring a hundred to do odd-jobs in the Eternal Throne."

"Really? I just know them as poorer servants. Though even some of the nobility use them. They're that competent?"

The smiling young woman stood there as Seraphel stared at Elena.

Elena Othonos, Cara's friend. It was the oddest thing.

The Helpful Servants were made up of people who volunteered or joined the organization and were given a class. Probably [Helpful Servant], though Seraphel couldn't confirm that.

They would stand at a shop, and you could hire them for a day, a week, or even longer periods. Some were even live-in, though most would go back to the shop. They were paid a low wage, but they had Skills that let them work hard. Seraphel had heard it being described by the shop attendants as 'tuning out' so they could focus on work without getting bored or annoyed at, say, scrubbing the floor.

It sounded sort of pleasant in a 'I would never do that' sort of way to Seraphel. But if you didn't notice yourself working, and then enjoying your time off...it must be a decent life. She supposed they had a lot of volunteers because the Helpful Servant shops were common enough for her to have seen them in Menorome.

But Cara *knew* Elena. Which made sense. Helpful Servants were people. Seraphel had just never heard of someone hiring their friend.

And apparently, Elena didn't think of Cara the same way. When they found her cleaning the Synphasia, Elena straightened up.

“I am contracted to Cara O’Sullivan for another four days. She is allowed to renew my contract, as she is paying for dedicated service. But if she has been sentenced as a criminal, my duties are over. I will return to my shop now. Thank you for telling me, Your Highness of Calanfer. If you would like to purchase my services or anyone else’s, please don’t hesitate to visit our shop! We serve Calanfer and every nation in Terandria now!”

“My. So widespread. But, ah, Cara asked me to take care of you, Miss Elena. I’m happy to pay for a vacation. I doubt you’d wish to join me in Ovela.”

Seraphel had the notion to simply make sure Elena was well, but she began to realize there was a problem when Elena tilted her head slightly. She had *marvelous* hair. A brunette’s, but glossy and well-cared for. It was pinned back in an unflattering bun, and Elena had a traditional [Maid]’s outfit on. It didn’t really work on her, but she didn’t seem to care.

Why would any young woman like her want this dreary job? Elena’s fingers were dirty with the filth from the run-down Synphasia’s inner rooms. But she didn’t jump at Seraphel’s offer like the [Princess] thought she would.

“I’m sorry, Your Highness, but I am at work. I do not accept gifts, and I will need to share my profits with the Helpful Servant shop if you give me any gold.”

“No, Miss Elena. I mean—I’d like to give you money to keep you from *working*. For Cara. Your friend.”

“Cara is not my friend. I—”

Elena hesitated, and then she *paused* and went still for a long second in such an odd way that Seraphel hesitated. Dalimont eyed her, and Mariel and Thistel nudged each other.

“What an odd class. Nothing as good as we are.”

“*Hush. Be nice, Mariel.* Just because you’re a fancy [Handmaiden of Honor]—”

Elena turned to Seraphel, and her face broke out of that helpful monotone, and she smiled.

“—Sorry, Your Highness, is it? I’ve never *met* royalty. This is amazing—I don’t actually know—Cara, did you say? She thinks we know each other because we’re from the same world. I suppose she has a point, but I *have* to work. I can’t accept a break. Sorry! Love my job.”

She smiled genuinely, and Seraphel nodded along...right until her nodding turned into a ‘huh’?

“Excuse me, Miss Elena? You’re from the same...”

Elena laughed, covering her mouth, then grimaced.

“Gross. Sorry, let me wash this off. Same planet. Earth. She’s been asking me how I got here and stuff, but I’m too busy to quit my job. Which she wants me to do. Sorry I was so blank back there. I tune out unless someone needs me. Do you want anything else?”

She turned, and Seraphel’s mouth opened wider. *Same planet.* Earth. Earth as in ‘dirt’?

Planet.

Pla. Net.

Seraphel knew a lot of words. She didn’t know that one. She turned to Dalimont.

“Dalimont, what is a ‘planet’?”

“I...don’t know, Your Highness. Should I look it up?”

Elena laughed at them.

“It’s a world! A body of dirt, water—the thing we’re standing on. It’s—everything! Darn. I guess that’s a secret to you people, huh? Well, if you’d like me to tell you about it—Cara paid for the full service, and we have a special rate on royalty. But I really do have to get back to my shop if you don’t need me.”

She was packing away her equipment, and Seraphel stared at her.

“I—would like to purchase your services.”

“*Wonderful*. How long?”

“Uh—ah—the rest of the month? Will you be like this?”

“Like—oh, *personal*? If you need me to. Otherwise, I’ll just do anything you need to the best of my abilities. It saves energy that way. It also costs a bit more if you want me to use my Skills.”

“I—I shall pay the full price. Thank you. And would you refresh me on the rules?”

Elena’s friendly smile blanked out again. Now, Seraphel was getting intensely weirded out. She was used to seeing the Helpful Servants doing things like this, and she just never...thought about it.

But planet? What did she mean the entire world? And now Seraphel listened quite intently to a familiar spiel.

“You are not allowed to harm, intimately touch, or otherwise impede Helpful Servants. Hiring them for crimes is forbidden. If any of these rules are broken, you will forfeit your payment immediately and they will return to their store. Further actions will result in the Watch or local authorities intervening.”

Elena’s voice was calm and steady. She didn’t even blink.

“Helpful Servants are contracted for a set period of time. We are not, usually, allowed to work on demand. Special arrangements may be made at the shop with any attendant. We are quite friendly and will socialize, talk

about your feelings, and if you want to shout or cry, go ahead. But we are not lovers. Anything you say is confidential—and we hope you enjoy our work!”

She smiled then. Seraphel blinked at Mariel.

“What do you think, Mariel?”

“Noblefolk scream at servants all the time, but it’s odd to hear her say you can do that. Er—not that *you* do it.”

Seraphel blushed as she and Mariel knew quite well she would take her temper out on her servants. And her sisters probably did throw things if they were mad. But it was—odd. Elena stood there, then her eyes shifted to Seraphel.

“I can begin work immediately if you would register my contract at a shop.”

“...Ser Dalimont can do that. He will be in charge of your services, Miss Elena. In fact, we’re going to Ovela.”

“Very good, Your Highness. I will need a place to sleep and to eat if I am travelling. And there is a price for what they would consider full service. Is that acceptable?”

“Very. Dalimont? Sort it out.”

Like that, Seraphel had a new helper.

An odd one. An odd one who had a lot of knowledge. And who was beginning to make Seraphel feel uneasy. And that was *before* she even got to Ovela.

Once she arrived there, Seraphel realized that Elena, Cara’s predicament, and Queen Cathiel’s wrath was all still in the backdrop of, well—

The beginning of an all-out war.

Sasi

When Ailendamus attacked, Sasi, Culin, Greina, and the ghosts had just met the Twins of Ovela for the second time.

Sasi hated them.

She had already disliked them from her parents talking about their tithes and how they never sent soldiers to help her father.

She hated them after they didn't reach Afiele in time. But Sasi would have forgiven them for not being able to fight through the undead horde.

However, Lord Fallien and Lady Piral Ovela were just—

They had blue hair. Blue, striking hair that came from marrying foreigners. Piral's was short-cropped, and she rode a huge warhorse and carried a lance all the time. Fallien strode around in plate armor, and his hair was shoulder-length, but he put it behind him in a ponytail.

They were both very fit, and Piral had a scar over her nose, Fallien had a big one across his hand. When he gave the children a handshake, he showed it to Culin.

"My sister gave me that in our first serious duel. She's got one on her nose from me, though she got me deeper. Do you like your sister, Lord Culin?"

"Yes, Lord Fallien."

The [Lord] gave him a surprised look, as if he hadn't expected that answer. Then he ruffled Culin's hair with an odd smile.

"Well, I hope you two never have to fight. We were born twins. We're still trying to work out who's the better one at leading."

"Or fighting. Or anything else. It's a shame to be so damn close, though I'm close enough to having a [Knight]-Order compared to Fallien, who thinks he'll serve Ovela by playing [General]. Lady Sasi, I was deeply sorry to hear about Lord Lantal's passing."

Piral swung down from the horse, and Fallien glared at her. Then he turned to Sasi.

“We both were. We tried to break through, but when we heard it was a full-blown horde—we ran into thousands of undead, and the Baron was attacking over the river. When we finally broke through...it was too late. I’m sorry. I’ll bet Ashwheat to gold it was Digernal behind the [Necromancer].”

They sounded sincere when they apologized about not being there. But the two...Sasi realized they spoke about each other and Digernal every other sentence. It wasn’t that they weren’t aware of the rest of the world. It was just that, somehow, it always revolved around what the other Twin thought—or the war.

“It’ll *be* war soon. These skirmishes...they’re getting bloodier. Digernal keeps rotating through Ailendamus’ endless armies, but we’re counter-leveling and holding the line. It’s a shame no one else knows how hard Ovela is fighting.”

“If they did, they’d give us enough support.”

Piral added sourly. She was letting them tour the keep.

The Ovelian Keep was one of Noelictus’ great strongholds. It didn’t have the tallest walls; they were only thirty feet, which was actually enhanced by long slopes of dirt that led up to the walls. It made for a difficult climb if you were taking it, though, and the real protection of the ancient keep was the huge weapon inside.

“What is *that*?”

Culin pointed in awe at the monstrous ballista, so huge it towered *over* the walls. Piral slapped her leg, and Fallien laughed as Grishen responded.

“That monster is the Hammer of Ovela. The biggest siege-weapon in Noelictus.”

“The biggest this side of the continent! It’s why Digneral has never had a foothold long on Ovela. He’s tried to blow it up, break it, or just burn it more times than we can count. But even the wood’s made of ancient stuff. Heartwood of a World’s Tree, from the Great Forests. It can hurl a ballista bolt dozens of miles—*whoops, there it goes!*”

Sasi went *deaf* as the ballista fired. Ancient rope *snapped* as all the stored energy of the bundles of twine *launched* a piece of wood so far and so fast into the sky that she lost track of it at once. The [Soldiers] cheered, and Piral and Fallien laughed.

“You should have seen Digneral falling back when we fought him just this morning!”

They had apparently finished an engagement with him, and there were wounded [Soldiers] and casualties and surrendered [Soldiers] in the keep—but they were in high-spirits.

“You seem jolly, for all that it’s been six years of skirmishing.”

Grishen did not appreciate either Twin, Sasi realized, and that fed into how she disliked them. Lord Fallien sombered and gave her a bow. Piral, a toss of the head.

They were alike and not alike. It was like they’d flipped coins on everything from how they handled politeness to everything else. Fallien took one approach, Piral, the opposite. It made them feel like, well, *twins*. Even when they were different, they were *alike in their differences*. If that made sense.

Fallien addressed Grishen politely.

“Duchess, you may say we’re not our father, and it’s true neither of us is [Earl]—”

“Yet. But we’re levelling faster than even he did. Both of us are Level 30—before we turned 30! For noble classes, that is tremendous, and once *I* become [Earl], Fallien can become a proud [Lord] of Calanfer. Or even a [Prince Consort] or something. That’s a decent class, Fallien.”

Neither one was [Earl]. Because they couldn't decide on who would inherit the position and power and because the old Earl hadn't decided the matter, the two were [Lord] and [Lady]. Grishen sighed.

"Earl Inameis has left a mess of Ovela, all because he couldn't pick one of you over the other. For such a good man, he was a fool in his last days."

Both twins glared at her, but Grishen was immune to it, just like everything else. She touched the handle of her mace.

"We won't stay long if there has been fighting."

"At least let the children see where their grain goes! It's to keep Ailendamus from sweeping over Noelictus, Lady Sasi, Lord Culin. And while we have you...where are these saviors of Afiele I've heard so much about from Fallien? My [Soldiers] said I would have to see these 'ghosts' with my own eyes!"

Piral laughed good-naturedly and made a show of looking around. None of the ghosts had yet shown themselves. Culin beamed, but Piral leaned over as Grishen and Sasi frowned, and Sasi realized the Twin was joking as she grew serious.

"What *was* Afiele's salvation? Adventurers? Some irregulars of yours, Grishen? Or did the [Hunters] sort it out?"

She didn't believe Afiele had ghosts! And neither did Fallien, though he'd been there! Grishen calmly sipped from a flask that held her tea, and Sasi piped up.

"It was ghosts, Lady Piral, Lord Fallien! They came from Afiele's tomb! Lord Fallien, you were there!"

Again, the Twins laughed, and this time, Sasi knew they were mocking her. Lord Fallien chuckled as he grabbed something he'd had leaning up against the wall.

It was a halberd. In fact—Lady Piral’s own weapon was a halberd as well, though she couched it like a lance when she rode around. They used the same weapon, and to see Fallien whirl it overhead without regard to the people nearby—he was an adept at it.

“Lady Sasi, I appreciate the joke, but ghost-tales do not frighten Ailendamus’ [Soldiers]. It got me the first time, before I came here and tried to tell Piral what had happened and I realized how silly it sounded. I would like to believe an army of legends would come marching out of Ovela’s own tomb, but truly. How did it happen?”

“Ghosts.”

Both children were earnest and glancing at the ground for some reason. Yet they waited for Fallien to beg to meet the ghosts again. Instead, the Lord of Ovela just laughed.

“Oh yes, the *ghosts*. It had me stunned...until I sat down that night and wondered what kind of illusion spell it was. You had us all fooled! The look on Piral’s face when I figured it out—*and* the [Hunters] and [General]. What was it really?”

Wait. He’d been there and he didn’t believe? Lord Fallien *had* arrived and seen the ghosts at a remove, but he had left soon after. Even so! Sasi gave him a strange look. *How could he think that was fake?*

“It was exactly what you saw, Lord Fallien. It was the ghosts of Afiele! You heard them speak, didn’t you?”

“Oh, I talked to someone. But painted or magicked armor and a few illusion spells is easy. Come on, Lady Sasi.”

Was he insane? Sasi traded a bewildered glance with Culin, but Lady Piral also sighed and gave Grishen a look.

“Is it secret? We do get spies in the keep, but they’re mostly here to sabotage our food supplies or the Hammer. We keep *asking* for [Hunters] or

experts in that kind of thing, but the crown is sparring with the Landsreight.”

“I’d almost throw in with Marquis Seelthru and try to stop paying tithes—but I can’t stand him.”

Fallien added. Piral scowled at him.

“Well, *I* am in Fiskren’s camp. And since we’re both one half of Ovela’s vote...nothing gets done! And if you think putting a [Princess] in your bed will sway anyone else—”

Alright. After five minutes, Sasi could no longer stand the Twins, and she understood why her father and mother had never taken them to visit. They *fought* so much they were like...her and Culin! But worse because they looked like adults!

Grishen was no less disapproving. She *smacked* the wall with her mace and got their attention.

“Lord Fallien. Lady Piral. Pay attention to Lord Sasi and Lord Culin. They are now the Lord and Lady of Afiele’s fields, and they have seen a [Necromancer] die and thousands of the undead, their people put to the torch. *Stop bickering and show them respect.* And understand that they are not lying to you.”

Chastised, Fallien and Piral looked at Sasi and Culin. They were sympathetic. Lord Fallien cleared his throat.

“...At least tell me my wife-to-be is alright. Princess Seraphel was well, I hope? I was glad she survived, though I’ve not met her properly. I hear she’s...sharp.”

He looked somewhat dismayed, and Sasi met his gaze resolutely.

“She was ever so nice to us, and she’s brave and good. You’ll like her, Lord Fallien.”

“I hope so. Now—are you going to show me any ghosts, Lady Sasi? Because I could use some to fight Ailendamus!”

He teased her, and a voice rang from the floor.

“In my youth, Ovela was both shield and sword of Noelictus. *That* has not changed, but the strength of Ovela is mightier in this thing you call the ‘Hammer’. *Weaker in the blood and bone of the land!* You come striding about when you should kneel and beg for not having been at Afiele’s side. And you forget we have *always* honored our vows.”

Paladin Arteis Ladel rose out of the ground as Ser Dalius and dozens of ghosts floated up with her. They had been, apparently, hiding underground, and now they *rose*, an army of spectral blue, a force of the dead.

Noble figures armed in blades all.

Piral and Fallien swung their blades at Arteis and Dalius with an oath.

“*Dead gods.*”

“*Shade breaks! Sound the—*”

Both their halberds cut the air, whistling—Arteis lifted her shield and knocked Fallien’s blade aside. Dalius parried Piral’s halberd, and the [Lord] and [Lady] staggered back before resetting their footwork.

The keep was abuzz with shouting, but the ghosts ignored the screams. Duchess Grishen smiled as one of the ghosts caught an arrow that flew at them, and Arteis shouted.

“*Lower your blades, sons and daughters of Ovela! Or do you not see your kinfolk?*”

The [Soldiers] looked up, and old Mustrec, a [Royal Halberdier] himself, grinned with gaps in his teeth.

“Ah, Ovela’s not changed much. Good to see they still practice the art of the halberd somewhere.”

“Wh—wh—”

Fallien was open-mouthed. Piral was faster than he to process things.

“*Ghosts!* But how—not even for the Creler Wars did they return! Are you—who are we addressing?”

Arteis saluted her with a sword, causing the [Lady] to jump back.

“I present the Tombwarden of Afiele, Ser Dalius of the Order of Shadowed Blooms! I am Paladin Arteis Ladel, Crusader of the Dawn Patrol! With me are Afiele’s honored dead, a small portion of those sworn to defend Noelictus in its dire hour. We rose when the Lord of the Fields called...but too late. We regret our subterfuge, Lady and Lord Ovela, but we were wary of spies. We noted six already.”

“More spies. How many? That’s more than normal.”

Instantly, both Twins strode to the battlements of the keep. Fallien groaned as he looked down at the staff and soldiers.

“There’s always one or two, but this many? With you lot? They’ll report to the Baron!”

“The capital knows. It was only a matter of time before the rest of Terandria caught on—but the ghosts will vanish. You can claim it was an illusion and hopefully cast a net over any reports going out.”

Grishen remarked. Piral nodded.

“Good idea. I’ll do that. Fallien, you lock down any horses! Anyone who leaves—I’ll have my lancers ready!”

“I’ll have the [Battlemages] monitor for [Message] spells and intercept. And greet our guests properly!”

The two ran off, then came rushing back to ask questions. Dalius murmured to the other ghosts who were sinking back into the flagstones.

“They do *squabble*.”

“Yes. I can see why Ovela is in trouble. But they’re at least decently strong. You nearly failed that parry.”

Arteis shot back. Dalius blushed.

“She’s quicker with a halberd than I thought. What classes are they?”

Fallien returned, beaming and bowing. He gestured to Piral, and Sasi and Culin took in the two high-level champions of Ovela.

“Why, I’m a [Lord of Sieges]! And Piral is a [Lady of the Battlefield]! Both over Level 30! And what level are you?”

The two ghosts saw him puff out his chest, as if thinking he had met peers among these legends. Dalius turned to Arteis, and Sasi remembered that each and every ghost here was...over Level 40.

She was giggling at Lord Fallien’s face when the first horns blew and everyone snapped to attention. Then Sasi’s heart jumped and lurched as she heard someone begin screaming that Ailendamus was coming.

Thousands of [Soldiers] marching behind the Baron of House Ecte.

Seraphel

When she arrived, the battle had mostly stabilized. Which was to say—Ovela was in trouble.

They were in trouble because the Twins kept attacking. She saw the tail-end of one of the battles on the way to the keep.

Torn standards of Ovela were marching back in disarray. Wounded [Soldiers] fleeing a battle. There was a tremendous, regular *thumping* sound of something massive firing into the air.

The Hammer of Ovela. The keep was...not impressive. It was a massive sprawling one, in the center of a huge dirt hill, but the Ovelian Keep really

wasn't more than a tactical nightmare to take.

It was not—grand. The Hammer of Ovela *was*.

Lord Fallien was, similarly, both more than Seraphel was hoping for and less.

He was a handsome man. She didn't know why that made her feel better, but his striking hair, his decently good looks, made her think that if she had children, they'd at least pass her mother's standards for not having to use illusion spells.

She didn't want to think on that. Also, Fallien didn't recognize her at first. He was arguing with a familiar woman that Seraphel was glad to see.

Duchess Grishen was shouting at both he and Piral.

"Each time you sally forth, the Baron sends you two scrambling back to the keep! He is bleeding Ovela dry, and only the threat of the crown's armies is keeping him back! Why are you attacking him?"

"We've beaten him before!"

Fallien tore at soot-covered hair furiously. A woman, Lady Piral, was having her arm bandaged, practically spitting fury on top of her horse. Grishen shot back.

"Yes, and it's clear now that he was always *letting* you win."

Fallien waved a hand at her as he turned to see the Thronebearers. He focused on them with puzzlement, then saw Seraphel.

There was...no static electricity of sudden anything between them. Seraphel just hoped she didn't have her snack on her face, and she thought he looked relieved as he saw her. He dipped his head—then hesitated and swung back to Grishen.

"If you would just send the *you-know-whats* with us—"

“The *ghosts* of Afiele are not your soldiers, Lord Fallien. Nor are Sasi and Culin meant to stay here. It’s clear that the roads are free. They will be leaving. I suggest you hold your armies back.”

“*We’d be able to rout the Baron if we had control of the army!* What is wrong with His Majesty? I—who are they, Fallien? Wait, is that your [Princess]?”

Lady Piral turned, and Seraphel curtsied slowly.

“Lady Piral, Lord Fallien. I am delighted to meet again, in more appropriate circumstances. I am Seraphel du Marquin. [Princess] of Calanf—”

The Hammer of Ovela *fired*, and she full-body flinched at the roar in the background. Fallien smiled, and Piral laughed. He strode forwards and took her hands in his gauntleted ones. They were warm, despite the metal, and Seraphel stared up at him.

“Your Highness of Calanfer. You needn’t have come here. Unless—does His Majesty intend on the wedding now? We are at war, and I was glad to know you were safe in Menorome. A pleasure. An honor, I should say. Are these your bodyguards?”

He turned to Ser Dalimont so fast Seraphel was left blinking.

He really is as focused on war as—as Lord Tyrion Veltras, the famous rock with a face carved on it of House Veltras!

He was at war. And he was a man. He had definitely looked her up and down and not been displeased.

Well, that’s better than before when it was just looks, and...I can do this. Seraphel smiled as Dalimont bowed.

“I am Ser Dalimont of the Order of Thronebearers, your lordship, your ladyship. I have sworn to protect Her Highness with my life. I hope my service will not be a displeasure to you.”

“Displeasure? No, not at all! Another sword in service to Ovela is welcome! Though if you are her bodyguard, does that mean—”

The Hammer of Ovela went off again, and Calanfer’s flinching was a contrast to how the Twins and the rest of the Ovelians barely noticed. They had to have no hearing after living like this!

“—Why don’t we take this inside? Your Highness.”

Fallien offered her his arm, and Seraphel headed inside to find Sasi and Culin.

“Seraphel!”

They threw their arms around her the moment they saw her, and she embraced them and felt better instantly.

“How are you two? You look so well! Are you alright? Are you worried about the war?”

Sasi beamed.

“We’re well! Thank you for all the treats! We shared them everywhere we went!”

“I missed you! Don’t go?”

Culin buried his head into Seraphel’s shoulder shyly, and Fallien’s bark of a laugh was surprised.

“I didn’t know you knew the Afiele family so well, Your Highness.”

Grishen saw him look carefully towards the ghosts and raised her voice.

“She was under siege with the lot of them. And she knows about the ghosts, Fallien. So you may speak freely here.”

“Calanfer does—”

He shot another look at the rest of Seraphel's escort coming in. Elena followed the rest, not looking as dismayed as Mariel or Thistel by being close to battle. She was blank, smiling—and gave Seraphel the chills now that she understood why Cara was so upset.

One thing at a time, though. Piral threw up her hands, annoyed as she strode into the mess hall.

“Let the world know of the ghosts! If they don't help—what's the point?”

She almost hurled her helmet to the side—and nearly collided with a disapproving Paladin Arteis. The woman's arms were folded, and she was standing with a number of ghosts who were, as always, protecting Sasi and Culin.

“One does not rush into battle blind, and yon [Baron] is far more of a threat than either you or your brother will admit, Lady Piral. He is the most dangerous living man I have laid eyes on yet. Moreover, as Duchess Grishen wisely says, *we are not under your command*. We are under Afiele's command.”

Piral rallied after a second of uncertainty.

“But we rule Afiele, Paladin Arteis. Or rather, we are the stewards of this province, and Afiele's lands are under our jurisdiction, though the Afiele family holds direct control.”

Arteis' scowl only deepened.

“We swore an oath to Afiele's Lord and Lady of the Fields. I would only *consider* heeding the crown of Noelictus itself. I am sworn to the land. To Sasi, Culin, and no others. If you wish for your dead to fight with you, beg the Tomb of Ovela to open!”

Piral's confidence turned to dismay, and she backed up. Fallien clearly relished that and nodded.

“Fairly said, great ghosts, but you can see Ailendamus is trampling over our lands!”

Dalimont coughed.

“We have just arrived, Lord Fallien. May we inquire about lodging? Is it safe? And if Her Highness is willing, a summary of recent events may not go amiss. I apologize for my forthrightness.”

“Oh—of course! Someone will help you find rooms. We have [Servants] aplenty, if not to Calanfer’s standards. As for the war, Digneral’s crossed the river. He’s begun fortifying hills, and the bastard has brought [Geomancers]. We’ve been trying to uproot him; he might be trying to dig in for the entirety of winter, and if he does, uprooting him in the summer will be twice as hard! I don’t see why the capital doesn’t grasp that!”

“Perhaps because he is baiting your attacks. It’s bad, Ser Knight.”

Grishen looked at Dalimont. She pursed her lips.

“He’s been holding back, but I can’t blame the Twins for struggling. They have held him with the Hammer of Ovela and Ovela’s skirmishing, but wherever those Drell Knights and his personal soldiers with their mirror-shields go, they win. And there’s a ‘Mirror Knight’ on the field. I saw him sending arrows straight back at the [Archers] who fired them.”

“Ser Ouren of the Order of Drell? I’ve heard of him. He’s close to Level 40, and they even considered him for the Thousand Lances of Kaaz.”

Dalimont winced. Seraphel bit her lip. She understood from that how bad it was.

Eight battalions of Ailendamus’ [Soldiers], armed in steel, and the Twins were trying to take fortifications backed by the gigantic Greatbows. To make matters worse, Baron Digneral was not the weakest link of his army.

“I swear, he copied my Skill out there. Did you see it, Fallien? The Drell Knights hit us *exactly* as hard as we hit them, even with [Zealous Charge]

and [Steelshorn Advance].”

“His shields deflect arrows and spells alike. I have to tell the [Archers] and [Crossbowmen] to aim for gaps, and the front lines report it feels like their blades get jarred from their hands if they so much as strike a mirror-shield.”

Glumly, Fallien and Piral had to admit that they were not winning. Then Fallien struck a knee.

“However, Noelictus’ armies have held him from advancing down the Vytorth Rivers. If they’d just flank him—”

“I believe I can answer that, Lord Fallien. I have heard from the Landsreight and His Majesty himself that he does not wish to escalate the war. They are there to contain Baron Digneral. But they will not be given to your control.”

“They what?”

Piral and Fallien were outraged. They began demanding answers, and only when Culin began to cry did the adults stop talking.

“I want to go *home*! Seraphel, let’s go home. Please? It’s loud here, and I hate it!”

He said the thing that Sasi clearly felt too. Seraphel bent down.

“Oh, Culin—of course you can go home! The roads are safe, but I’m afraid I’m staying here. I have to be wed.”

“No! You have to come to Afiele too!”

He grabbed at her, and Seraphel tried to get him to stop crying. He was just a boy. As if for the first time, Piral kicked at the ground and looked around at the wounded soldiers and the blood, the thumping of the Hammer...

“It occurs to me this isn’t a place for children.”

“Wonderfully observed.”

Grishen's voice was grating, but she stepped over to Culin and laid a hand on the boy's back.

"I stayed only so you two could see Princess Seraphel, Culin. I will take you back."

"Of course. And, er—we should make arrangements for Her Highness. Where's our [Seneschal]? Rodiet, where are you, man? Let's leave the talk of war till tomorrow. We're in no condition to sally, anyways."

"Plus, you have a wedding to arrange."

Piral gave Seraphel a long look, and the [Princess]' heart jumped. Fallien turned and looked embarrassed.

"So I do. We had planned on it before the siege and before the invasion. I will apologize to King Reclis myself, Your Highness. Did he...he did say he had a contingency. When are we to be wed? Menorome?"

She gave him a smile like a ghost herself as Ser Dalimont came over to comfort Culin, and he paused as the [Princess] replied.

"We can have the wedding within the hour or anytime that suits Ovela, Lord Fallien. Anywhere as well. Calanfer is no stranger to dire circumstances."

Fallien blinked at Seraphel, then smiled in relief. She heard the Hammer *thump* again and the ground shake, like wedding bells.

Oh.

She thought she would hate it here.

King Reclis du Marquin was not the one who planned weddings. That was his wife's job. He was the one who decided whether the weddings happened, and in this case, whether he wanted a large one.

There was Calanfer's prestige to consider and the opportunity to show off and invite guests and cement Seraphel as part of Noelictus.

Then again, she was the 'Cursed Princess' and this was her third marriage. So it might be a bit farcical to pretend this was her first wedding.

Moreover, he knew that Lord Fallien was not actually that enamored with Seraphel, and given the war, Reclis had sensed a chance to save a lot of wedding money and spend on the war—as well as get the marriage sealed without more uncertainty.

In fact, the allowance Seraphel had received at Menorome? That was a portion of her wedding budget, as it turned out, and Reclis had promised the rest to Ovela directly for the war funds.

That alone made Piral of Ovela happy enough that she threw open the castle's larders and stores to celebrate her dear brother's wedding. The occasion was marked with servants and [Soldiers] and the citizens of Ovela coming to celebrate their Earl.

All who could arrive in a day. Ser Dalimont performed the vows, and Seraphel heard silence as even the Hammer of Ovela ceased firing long enough for the two to swear faithfulness, duty, and love until death parted them.

Twenty minutes. Then it fired again, eighteen seconds after they kissed. And Seraphel thought...

Good.

Her first wedding had been a disaster. She had been numb from the failed engagement and at being shuffled off to an old man over eighty years old. She had been sixteen.

She tried not to remember it; it had been lavish, and her father had attended and given a great speech, and she didn't remember a thing.

Her first husband had married her because he was old and Calanferian, and if he turned his lands over to the crown rather than his heirs...well, it made him happy.

The second time she'd been engaged, the wedding hadn't been as opulent, but Earl Diroel had tried. He had already paid—*paid* quite a lot to marry a [Princess].

After all, they had to give Calanfer more than the Eternal Throne invested in them.

The Earl Diroel was a noble of Nadel, and the marriage was allowed for a number of concessions, gold being one of them, to strengthen ties in a small way to their neighbors.

The third time was to Ovela, so that the Kingdom of Shade and Calanfer might draw closer against the common enemy of Ailendamus.

It was just as well the wedding wasn't fancy and it was quick. Preparing for it would have given Seraphel no joy. After all, she did not know Fallien. Perhaps that was best for both of them.

Her mother had probably told Reclis to make it impromptu. King Reclis du Marquin thought of many things. But he did not often think of the [Princess]' role once all the vows were said.

The wedding night...was not something Seraphel had ever talked to anyone about besides her mother. Some of her sisters were happy enough in their marriages.

Then again, Aielef was cheating on her husband. Menisi might actually like hers. Shardele seemed content, but it was hard to tell. Vernoue, Lyonette, and Ellet...

Her brothers were all happy with their spouses, if not where they were. Prince Lothen, her younger brother, had once remarked that he felt like a [Princess]' job was far easier than a [Prince]'s, especially after the

weddings were done. She didn't understand how he could sleep in a bed next to someone he didn't know.

But then again, she'd observed that her husbands got more out of the wedding night than she did.

Lord Fallien had a discussion with Seraphel after their vows, when they retreated to his quarters in the Ovelian keep. His rooms were distressingly small.

They were large for a keep. Small for Seraphel. He had a main room and a dressing room, which doubled as the entryway.

His armor and clothes were scattered around, and, much embarrassed, he confessed that he often didn't do much with the room until it needed cleaning.

It was certainly a single man's room, and Seraphel noted countless books on his shelves. Stories of famous heroes, like the Lightning Thief, autobiographies, or memoirs by famous leaders.

The Titan of Baleros' personal book on war. The King of Destruction's rise, by Krsysl Wordsmith. It wasn't hard to see what Lord Fallien wanted to be.

At least he was honest. At least he seemed to be decent enough.

Earl Diroel had come in with a grudge against Seraphel. Not because she had gotten on his nerves; she'd tried at the start, but he'd known she had already been wed. So he had constantly tried to undo history and time by proving he was more than her first husband.

Maybe that was why he'd gotten himself killed, snapping at a Kaazian [Lord] who challenged him at a banquet and ran him through in a duel afterwards.

Her second husband had died in bed, of sepsis from the wound. Seraphel had found him lying there and wept in relief.

These were the things that the 4th Princess of Calanfer told no one. They were just facts, and it was why, until Afiele, she truly had just sat and stared out the window of her carriage. Meeting Lantal's family, living in Afiele, meeting Cara, going to Menorome, had put something back in her.

The [Princess] who sat on the bed looked like a doll. Her hair was still pinned back by a tiara, and she wore a wedding dress—the same one Aielef had worn to her wedding when she married into Kaliv, adjusted for Seraphel.

Aielef had kicked up a fuss when Ielane demanded it, but the pearl-inlaid dress was expensive...and it would be bad luck for Seraphel to wear the same gown she'd worn to the last ill-fated marriage.

"Your Highness? Seraphel?"

She started when he said her name. Then Seraphel gave Fallien a smile.

"I apologize. I'm just—overwhelmed, Lord Fallien."

"I believe it's Fallien now we're married. Strange. Ah—Seraphel."

Oh, they were strangers. Ielane sometimes talked about how odd it had been for her to marry and be so familiar with someone and learn their intimacies, but Seraphel had known this man less than a day.

And still. He was honest. Fallien sat on his bed, which was covered in a pelt rug.

"Wolf-fur. I, uh, like to hunt. I should be honest and say that I don't know if you care to, Seraphel. But I think you know that this marriage is largely for convenience's sake."

Her lips quirked.

"I...would hate to lead you on, Lord Fallien. I did enter into it with good intentions, but I would be lying if I said I had known you before it was set up."

Lord Fallien laughed, relieved, again.

“You’re quick! I’m—relieved, you know. I was worried you’d be—”

“Old? Ugly?”

“No! I had pictures of you. But I did, uh, hear you were once known as sharp-tongued.”

“That was a nickname.”

She had to explain it, and he nodded.

“I was nervous you’d be so upset—well, I cannot blame you. I want you to know that I do hope to be a good husband. My sister, you know, is vying with me for the Earlship. And this keep, this war with Ailendamus in all but name, is no place for a [Princess]. I intend to let you—offer you the chance to reside in Menorome, if you wish. I’d visit. Or Afiele. I didn’t realize Lord Culin and Lady Sasi liked you so well. They’re good children. It was tragic what happened with Lord Lantal and Lady Risel. We did come as soon as we could, but—”

This was not appropriate talk for a wedding night, but they were doing the wedding first. Understanding each other after. Seraphel nodded.

“That’s—kind of you, Lord Fallien. You don’t need to accommodate me if it is a strain. I am prepared to live however’s appropriate for Noelictus.”

“It’s no strain. Actually...it would be nice to have someone who can attend the Landsreight and represent us in court. You caused a stir, I heard.”

He’d only heard the good parts, so Seraphel breathed a sigh of relief. Fallien went on.

“I don’t want you to be unhappy. In fact, if you wish to ride or visit other countries, I’m sure we could figure it out. Those Thronebearers are quite—shiny.”

“They’re very good guards. Not so much useful in war, but my staff can help you as much as I can.”

At least to clean your rooms and keep spies out. There might be a thousand listening spells in his rooms. Having a [Princess] of Calanfer on your side often had benefits most nations didn’t think of.

Fallien nodded a few times and then took a deep breath. He smiled at Seraphel.

“It doesn’t have to be unpleasant, this marriage, Your Highness. I’m glad you see it the same way. I think it could work out quite well. And we might find we truly do like each other.”

She gave him a genuine smile, then.

“That would be the best outcome. I could earnestly try to do that.”

He grinned, then, and they talked a bit more, and she made him laugh when she described her first introduction to the Court of Dusk. He confessed that he really hadn’t left Noelictus much, and the offer to marry a [Princess] had fallen into his lap.

“I truly thought ‘really, me?’ My sister always makes me feel inferior. We fight because...neither of us wants to admit the other’s better. She’s better with a sword, I have more of a head for books. We’re just a bit different, but not enough.”

“When did you start becoming rivals and not friends? Were you ever close?”

Fallien sat on his bed a second longer.

“We were. I don’t remember when we became the worst enemies. I think—well. I think it was when we learned only one of us could become [Earl]. No, wait. That’s not right. We realized it was up to us, and when we thought about sharing...I thought I could do it better than her. I really did. And it turned out she thought exactly the same as me.”

He gave her another embarrassed look.

“Maybe you’ll be the thing that helps us settle this once and for all. That would be a tremendous blessing.”

Then, during the night, they consummated the marriage.

[Conditions Met: Widow Princess → Gloomy Princess class!]

[Gloomy Princess Level 19!]

[Skill – Comforting Bed Partner obtained!]

—

To Seraphel, it was mercifully quick. If she had to compare it—and the memories were strongest *now*, afterwards, as Fallien dressed to check on the keep and she pretended to sleep—it was awkward, embarrassing—and she had not been her the entire time.

Like a ghost, she felt. That was how she dealt with it. She became a ghost and floated away from her body and watched for a bit.

—Better than the old Viscount and the Earl. He was younger, she was older, and Fallien was not ready for heirs. He’d actually wilted a bit in more senses than one when she brought it up.

“I—would rather adopt Lord Culin or Lady Sasi first, to be honest. I don’t have time for children.”

He’d confessed, worried she would insist. Seraphel had felt a mix of emotions.

“Them? Would that even be allowed?”

“Well, if not adopt, raise them. They’re good children, and if they like you—but no. I just meant that I don’t need children. Not right now. Not until I’m either an [Earl] or not.”

So, Seraphel had one less thing to worry about. For now. Perhaps her mother wouldn't even ask for children; she had plenty with the other siblings, and they would be more powerful matches. Then again, Calanfer bloodlines were a powerful thing.

For now, it wasn't a worry. Another better-than-expected thing. Seraphel hadn't been hurt in bed. Intentionally. She might get to travel, or at least stay in Menorome, and she could patch things up with Kadane.

Cara was still alive, or so Dalimont assured her. The wedding had been fast, Fallien was considerate of her, and Piral didn't seem to regard her as an enemy.

Seraphel lay in bed before she decided to leave. Just in case Lord Fallien returned. It was silly, but she had to.

She couldn't stop the tears from coming out.

Sasi

When Sasi found Seraphel, the [Princess] was in the hallway, crying and trying to find somewhere to hide. Sasi had rooms in the inner keep, so she'd heard Seraphel's voice from outside.

"Seraphel?"

Arteis wasn't here. She was visiting the other ghosts, talking about something important; Sasi had seen her sink through the floor.

"Sasi! Why are you awake? It's late. I'm—fine."

"Did—did Lord Fallien do something bad?"

Sasi was uncertain, but Seraphel gave her a smile and tried to wipe at her face.

"No. He didn't. I'm fine. Just overwrought."

That was a lie, but Sasi wasn't sure what part. She stood there, not knowing what to do when an adult cried. So she took Seraphel's hand.

"You can sit in my room. No one will check on you but Arteis."

When the two sat on Sasi's rougher bed in the stone keep, with the Hammer of Ovela still *thumping* every few minutes—it was hard to sleep at all—Seraphel calmed down.

"Is it—hard getting married?"

Sasi understood a bit, but not all of it, and Seraphel was not about to elaborate.

"It's hard marrying someone you don't know, Sasi. That's all. It's a [Princess]' job, but I hope you never have anything like it."

"...I didn't know it was so hard."

Sasi had never thought about Seraphel getting married. She knew that was why the [Princess] had come here, but it had never occurred to her to think about it. Seraphel shook her head.

"It will be fine, Sasi. Please, don't mention this to anyone. I'm happy enough. Lord Fallien seems like a decent man, and I may be able to visit you or go to the capital. It would be good to show you around. You deserve to see it more often. I'm just—sad. It's not Fallien's fault. This brings back memories."

"Of..."

"I was married twice before, Sasi. This was better than those other times. Far much so."

That...wasn't...better to hear. But Seraphel seemed to think it was encouraging to say, and so Sasi just sat there, hugging Seraphel slightly. Her heart hurt.

"I'm glad you're here. Culin missed you and cried every night."

“I won’t go so soon, Sasi. I promise. In fact, I am Princess Seraphel of Ovela, now. Of Calanfer *and* Noelictus. So I’m glad to be here with you. But why don’t we go for a walk? I could...use some fresh air. Are we allowed to walk around the keep?”

“Just the insides. There’s guards on the inner keep, but there is a study and paintings. I can show you.”

The Ovelian Keep was large, and so the inner keep had such luxuries as a study and more amenities than Afiele’s own tiny keep had had.

If just. Seraphel saw a line of [Earls] that went back fifty-two unbroken generations, and Sasi stared solemnly up at Earl Inameis.

He had a blue mustache. A slightly receding chin, but he looked serious, brave, and she had no idea if he had been as good as they said. She tried to imagine what the two portraits of a younger Fallien and Piral had been like. Even there, they looked wild and energetic.

“The roots of Noelictus go back far. fifty-two generations and some lived over a hundred years. And that’s only this particular bloodline in straight continuation. That’s...far more than most Calanferian bloodlines, and Ovela isn’t even the oldest house. Yours is, Sasi.”

The girl shrugged.

“Is Calanfer that new, Seraphel? Isn’t it six thousand years old?”

“Oh, yes. But it was founded after the Creler Wars. History goes back *far* before that, Sasi. Entire eras lost to history. My kingdom is new. My *blood* is new. Just look at Ser Dalius and Paladin Arteis. They are so old they don’t know what Crelers are.”

That was amazing to both living mortals. Sasi bit her lip.

“Arteis is scary, you know, Seraphel. She gives me orders, and she wants me to be strong.”

“She reminds me of Dame Vensha or my mother. Tough women—even if my mother is as good with a sword as I am. Maybe there’s a nicer ghost you could ask to guard you?”

Sasi scuffed at the carpet. She stared at the older [Earls] and saw them looking down on her from history. Some of the portraits were *old*. So old the paint was flecking away, despite preservation magic. One was of a woman who looked most like chicken scratches and ruined paint on wood. It looked spooky by the single candle both had for light.

“Maybe. I like her, though. I like her and she’s scary. She keeps saying she’ll fix things.”

“Maybe she will. Maybe she’ll make *you* a Duchess, and you can outrank me in some ways as I’m just an [Earl]’s wife. But never Grishen.”

Seraphel made Sasi giggle.

“I don’t want that! But I am glad the ghosts came back.”

The [Princess] nodded. Then her face grew clouded.

“Me too. I just wonder why. After all this time...”

“They were sworn to, you know. It is an oath in rock and stone and soul. But oaths fade. Strange they should remember now. Stranger still I noticed not their lack. Holes in the memory. Holes in the knitting. *Alas. Alack.*”

Sasi...stopped smiling, and Seraphel’s face grew puzzled—then alarmed. Neither one of them had spoken that last bit. But the voice was deep, groaning, and it seemed to come from all around them.

Then the eyes of the ruined [Earl]’s painting shifted, and they were orange and black lines, circles upon circles. And Belavierr’s lips moved and spoke through the wood.

“Lady of the Fields. And stranger I know not who wears a [Princess]’ aegis. I greet thee. I offer three questions for three. May we have an accord? I

return now with more questions than answers. I come in peace, though I needed wait till the ghosts my presence ignored.”

She stepped out of the wall. Her face had been merged *with* the painting. She pulled herself out of the stone and wood, and Seraphel screamed.

“*Help! H—*”

The scream never made it out of the study. It was loud, at first, but Sasi saw Belavierr *grab* the scream, and no one heard it. She grabbed the echo and tucked it into her robes.

“*Who are you? Stay back! Guards? Guards!*”

Seraphel’s circlet flashed warningly as she grabbed Sasi. She called for Dalimont and anyone else, but again—the Stitch-Witch had them in a private moment.

Time out of time.

Seraphel knew her. She had never met this woman before, but she *knew* her. Instinctively. It was the chill of the marrow of her bones. A dread certainty.

This was no woman. This was an idea. She turned her head, and those eyes glowed like the very image of Rhir’s hells in Seraphel’s mind.

She looked like...the nightmare who stood behind the door given life. The crawling woman drowned in the well. The [Witch] at the back of your mind. Not the one you pictured when it was daylight and sunny. *This woman—Belavierr—*was the chill running down your spine long after the sun had fallen and you saw a figure walking down the road.

She was horror. And tall, looming over Sasi and Seraphel. If anything, it was a wonder the girl didn’t scream. But she was born of Noelictus, and she shouted.

“*Go away! I don’t want to speak to you!*”

“Little Lady of the Fields, don’t be so quick to turn me away. I have the right to come before your door.”

“Go *away!*”

Belavierr *wavered* as she stepped out of the wall, and Seraphel joined her voice.

“Leave, apparition! Spirit! Witch! By royal Calanfer and the Eternal Throne—whomever you are, *stay away!*”

She tried to lend her weak authority as a [Princess], push with her weak aura at the [Witch]. Her mother had said that if any of the family were talented with their aura, they might have used it like a weapon in war. A [Princess] could stand against a [Mage] by sheer force of will.

It was a mistake. She pushed and *fell* into Belavierr’s wake. It wasn’t like running up against a wall like Queen Cathiel.

Seraphel felt as if she had just fallen into a cold, dark lake. Her skin went numb, and she stopped breathing. She clawed at her throat—but the [Witch]’s power dragged her down. She felt her heartbeat stop—and those eyes fixed on her and not Sasi.

Annoyance—Seraphel staggered away, and Sasi grabbed her.

“Stop it! Stop it! And go away!”

“You have no right to speak to me, little [Princess]. I am older than your entire claim. *No lineage newly come to Terandria may force me.*”

The [Princess] *breathed* as those eyes turned to Sasi, and the [Witch] inclined her hat.

“Little Lady of the Fields, Sasi Afiele. You have every right to turn me away. But I *am* a guest in this land of shades. I have the right to approach you. Will you not hear my say?”

Sasi was turning from Seraphel to Belavierr, and when the [Witch] looked again—Sasi protectively spread her arms. Shaking, she raised her voice.

“Okay. Will you go away if I listen?”

Her response was a smile. Belavierr bowed slightly, arm covering her stomach.

“Excellent. I have made inquiries. Our meeting last was prematurely aborted. It seems we have a deal, after all, to be made. So here is my first question of three: your ghosts...will you sell them to me? I have assessed their value and reconsidered my position. They are not worth a resurrection, but I have precious items for trade.”

Her ghosts? Sasi looked suddenly guilty as she glanced at Seraphel, but the [Princess] was just inhaling the cold, stale air into her lungs.

“Y-you can’t have them. I can’t sell them. I don’t own them.”

“Oh, I know. I have a net and a jar. I only need your permission. I have the authority of this land. It will not be hard.”

*A net and a—*Sasi and Seraphel’s eyes met wildly, and Belavierr produced something. A tiny, little net, a miniature one she held between her fingers, less than a foot long.

But Seraphel realized the thread was finer than any spiderweb in the Court of Dusk. She couldn’t even see the threads, she realized. It looked like it could catch every mote of dust in the world. And the jar—

It seemed to draw in her eyes and the light, and Belavierr covered it gently.

“A simple little trade. In exchange for your permission, I will pay you a fine fee.”

“My parents?”

Seraphel looked at Sasi’s pale face, and Belavierr hesitated.

“No. It is still not worth my craft. But come and see. *Come and see.*”

She lifted a fold of her robes, and Seraphel stared as the dark blue cloth moved like a curtain. Then gold poured forwards.

Golden coins, so many they flooded into the keep. Old gold—not newly minted coins. *Real gold.* The luster was subtler, but the [Princess] knew value.

This was old money. Stamped with crude symbols. *[Pirate] doubloons?* Ancient gold—and even other coins. Not silver, Seraphel realized. Mithril coins, jewels as fat as her head—

A fortune more than Calanfer’s entire budget in a year spilled out of Belavierr’s robes. She caught a single jewel.

“Children love little riches, and I have a diamond big as your head. Say yes, little one? Just nod your head.”

She offered it to Sasi, and the girl backed up, stiff and still.

“No! Not Arteis or Dalius. Are you...are you mad?”

“Not them? Not for ten times these riches? *What about a ship? I have a ship in the deeps.* It is old and wet, but it was made by an Archmage. Do you want a ship? A horse? I could catch you a wild one. No more Unicorns...I think. But a pretty pony?”

“No!”

Was she mad? She sounded...off. Belavierr was terrifying, but also looked—confused. She seemed to think that appearing out of a *wall*, offering gold and a— a pony or a ship would make Sasi want to make a deal with her.

This nightmare was confused and looked down at Sasi’s face.

“Strange. Am I...this is why Wiskeria should be here. To negotiate in my place. Where did she go? Have you seen my d—”

She paused.

“Ah, but I asked, didn’t I? I...no, that was not my question. Two remain. Tsk. Tsk. Such a pain. This is getting hard...this is...”

The [Witch] passed a hand over her face, frowning.

“...Going well? Business is well, but it was *strange*. Girl, Lady Sasi of the Fields, I have a second question for you. And I will reward it with a great favor if you know the answer. Do you know—if there are mice around?”

She turned, and even she seemed to realize the question was inane. Sasi stared at her.

“Mice? In the keep?”

“No. In the lands of the dead. *In my work*? See? I found this when I checked. All wrong. Who could have done this?”

Belavierr pulled something out of her robes, and Sasi and Seraphel screamed. This time—it was a tapestry. Of Belavierr, of a horrible design. It looked like nothing Seraphel had ever seen.

It dripped and oozed, and it was made of string like flesh. Of spiderwebs and shadows and more. If there was a way to weave a soul—it was in that tangled web. And it showed a single thing. A woman.

Belavierr stared out of the tapestry. She spoke, woman and image.

“Something is wrong with me. Look. There are little holes. I have been nibbled at by mice. In my dreams.”

She pointed, and Seraphel, unwillingly, saw *holes* in the tapestry. In... Belavierr. Something had indeed taken pieces out of that horrid mess, and the [Witch] folded it up.

“When I spoke to you, child, I looked around and found this. *Not good*. Something is lurking around, and it nibbled and stole my power. Do you know what? If you do, tell me and I will do you a great service. Slay an

army. Poison a rival. Give you ten years or a mighty object. Tell me who *stole from me*. And I will strangle them and their entire line. *Nothing eats at me.*”

Her eyes flashed. Sasi hid behind Seraphel, and the [Princess] spoke.

“We—we have no idea what you’re speaking of, Lady Belavierr.”

“*Witch!* To you, little [Princess]. Do not call me lady, but [Witch].”

Wrath came for Seraphel again, and she cowered—but it was gone in a heartbeat. Belavierr stepped back and lowered a clenched hand. Then regarded it as if mystified.

“...Wrong. All wrong. I am...in pieces. I must repair. *Who is nibbling at me?* How? Where? That—that is not my third question.”

She stood there, and Seraphel began to hope. *This ancient thing was wounded or confused!* So she tightened her grip on Sasi’s arms.

“Ask your third question and begone, Witch! That’s how it works, right? Contracts and deals? Three for three. Do we get three? Oh, shit—”

“That was one.”

Belavierr turned, and her smile was unpleasant, refocused, and filled with glee. She seemed to understand this, even if she was confused about the rest.

“Seraphel? Is it like a Djinni’s three wishes?”

“I think so. *That wasn’t the second, you know!* What’s your third question, Witch? Then we get two.”

“That was your second.”

“*That’s not fair!*”

Seraphel and Sasi shouted at once, and Belavierr's stare made them cower. The [Witch] just smiled.

"You addressed it to me directly, and I had an answer. My third question is this: have you seen my daughter? Wiskeria is her name, and—no—"

"You asked me that already! I don't know!"

Sasi pounced this time, and it was *Belavierr's* turn to scowl. Then she closed her eyes.

"A shame. Memory. The business spreads me thin. *My web of false deaths nibbled at.* The pact remains. Ask your third question, little Lady of the Fields, strange [Princess]. Or are you tempted to take up my offer?"

"N—"

Seraphel clapped a hand over Sasi's mouth, and Belavierr looked actually disappointed.

"A shame. Ask, ask."

What do you ask a [Witch]? Seraphel had no context, nor any idea of what to say. But Sasi was looking to her, and the [Princess] said the first thing that came to mind.

"Do you know why only a fraction of the ghosts of Afiele rose, Witch? Or why only Afiele's?"

Belavierr frowned deeply.

"No. The old ways called me to the Lady of the Fields as we often strike such deals. But I only thought it had been a long time. That is your answer."

"You didn't do it?"

Belavierr paused as she stepped back. Then, and only then, Seraphel heard a shout.

“Raise the halls! Lady Sasi! To arms!”

Arteis. Belavierr tarried a second as she sank into the wall. Her orange eyes flicked up sardonically as ghosts poured forth. This time, Arteis howled.

“I see you, Spider! Begone!”

She raised a flaming sword, and Belavierr sneered. She flicked a hand up and stopped Ser Dalius’ strike. Blocked it with a...*knitting needle*? The ghost whirled back, struck—

“The deed was not mine.”

Then a dozen blades tore across the wall, shredding the old pictures of the Earls of Ovela, cutting stone—but Belavierr was gone and the Ovelian Keep up in arms. Seraphel held Sasi as the girl shuddered.

Oh, this was getting worse and worse. First a conspiracy. Then a war and [Witch]. And when the ghosts turned to her...Seraphel realized they *knew* her.

Thus, she first heard of the Spider of Terandria, the Stitch-Witch Belavierr. Felt her creeping around Noelictus’ lands. She was interested in Sasi. And *that*—that scared even Arteis.

Seraphel

In the following week, Sasi and Culin did not head back to Afiele or House Ladel’s lands. Not because the war had stopped them from travelling. Rather, it was because Seraphel stayed at the keep.

Lord Fallien and Lady Piral had begged the ghosts for their aid, but they had abstained as one. So, clearly, Fallien realized that the two children clung to Seraphel.

If she stayed, so did they. He explained it to her, reasonably, the second night when she asked why. He was a reasonable man.

She did not love him or find that horror of intimacy with a stranger any better. But the news of Belavierr and the reaction of the ghosts—and her parents—let her distract herself aside from when they met in private.

Belavierr. It was a name Seraphel thought she'd heard before. Somehow. From her parents? From whispers or...storybooks?

"She is the Spider. She was the Spider when I was a girl, and Rhir's hells themselves are too good for her. She makes pacts with anyone desperate or foolish, and she has the power to do almost anything. The Dawn Patrol had tried to slay her."

"As had the Order of Shadowed Blooms. Or rather—we simply knew her, not that we ever went to war with the *Spider* herself. We thought her dead, honestly."

Ser Dalius and Dame Arteis regarded her completely differently. Arteis had known Belavierr was alive in her time and saw her as a great threat.

Ser Dalius had thought she was dead, but knew her like a name of myths. Arteis frowned at him.

"You were born long centuries after I, Ser Dalius. Did the Order of Shadowed Blooms truly forget such a great foe?"

He looked defensive as he stood with Seraphel, the Twins, and the children, who sat close to Duchess Grishen. The old woman's hand was trembling as she patted Sasi's hair. Dalimont hesitated.

"With respect, Paladin Arteis, no one had seen her for over three centuries. It would be like asking if...a Dragonlord yet lived."

"They make themselves known, one feels."

Arteis folded her arms, and Culin goggled at her. *A Dragon?* No one had seen a Dragon in—Dalius blew out his cheeks.

"So you say. But the only Dragonlord in my time I knew for a certainty who was alive or dead was the Tyrant of Jewels. Muzarre met his end. Gnolls

slew him in Izril.”

“*The Tyrant is dead?*”

Arteis broke into a huge smile, and three of the ghosts present cheered. Seraphel raised a hand.

“Excuse me, who is that? Do you mean *Az’muzarre*, the Gnollish tribe?”

Dalius, the ghosts, and everyone else blinked at her.

“No, Muzarre, the Tyrant of...ah. Clever. They named themselves *Az’muzarre*. That means ‘Death of Muzarre’. Yet another thing we should have compared, Tombwarden. I knew him as the living foe of Izril. Sovereign King of Salazar. That wretched deathbringer and his army of Drake minions.”

Arteis and the ghosts’ reminiscences on lost legends quickly turned back to Belavierr. Seraphel’s reservations only grew, because if there was a pecking order of great legends, it went from the mortals living in the here and now to the ghosts of Noelictus’ past—and Belavierr was older than them. *An ancient evil*—but one with rules, it seemed.

“The era of her striding battlefields and reaping souls ended before I was born, it seems. She makes pacts—promise her nothing, Lady Sasi. I don’t know how she slips in—she normally needs rules like a damned devil. Lord Fallien! Have you a pact with the Spider? She should not be able to step into your keep without demanding entry!”

Arteis whirled on him, and he held up his hands.

“I’ve never met any—Spider, Paladin! I swear it! Piral?”

“Not me. Nor would father deal with a [Witch]. They’re like [Necromancers]—dangerous with all the death magic in Ovela.”

The ghosts were talking. One scratched his chin.

“Perhaps an Earl of old gave her entry. She has more deals and ties than any [Pactkeeper].”

Arteis folded her arms, her eyes blazing with fury.

“Possibly. But she also appeared on Lady Sasi’s lands—we cannot leave Lady Sasi at any moment, it seems! Nowhere unguarded, or Lord Culin. Not sleeping, not even for a second. Not bathing or the privy—”

“You can’t come into the bathroom with me!”

Paladin Arteis was unmoved as Sasi shrieked in indignation.

“Would you rather meet Belavierr? She takes advantage of every weakness.”

“I doubt she’d be as scary poking out of a toilet seat.”

Dalius commented, and Culin began giggling. Seraphel held a hand over her mouth, and Arteis colored darker blue then swung about.

“Tombwarden! She is no joke!”

“Pardon, Arteis. Pardon.”

He held up his hands apologetically, and Piral shook her head.

“Well, if she’s gone—is she an agent of Ailendamus, perhaps? Could they have hired her?”

“Woe to us if they did. And if they paid her—she’d have the power to raze this entire keep. Though they’d pay a thousand innocent souls for the least of her tricks.”

Arteis’ words were dark and ominous, and Seraphel shuddered with everyone else, but it was fairly clear that Belavierr was not aiding Baron Digneral, and so Fallien stood with a sigh.

“Well, we have a war to win. Even if we can’t assault his fortifications—Piral, we have to keep his patrols from burning the farmlands and salvage what we can.”

“—You’re going back to war?”

Seraphel was mildly incredulous. A [Witch] of legends in their midst—but Lord Fallien gave her a smile.

“Your Highness—Seraphel—I’m focused on mortal men. Ghosts? Witches? Better leave that for [Mages] and their like. An *army* of [Soldiers]—now that I can deal with.”

The issue of Belavierr did not stop there, of course. Over the course of the day, the ghosts searched everywhere for her, but with little hope of finding her trail.

As for Duchess Grishen, she uttered a warning of her own when Fallien had gone. Piral was reassuring Sasi.

“I don’t know about guards in privies, but you have the might of Ovela’s keep. I assume that [Witch] can still be fought?”

“You’d be wise never to try, Piral. Nor is she the mysterious dead woman you think. If you ever meet her—hear her out and send her on her way. Better women than you or I have fallen to her trap.”

Piral, Sasi, and Seraphel turned.

“—You’ve met her. Grishen! Did you—?”

“I have made no pact with that [Witch]!”

Grishen snapped, but her hands shook as she held onto the mace. She took a deep breath, then looked at Seraphel.

“Your mother will know of her. Most [Ladies] of my age have met that Witch. In their dreams, at their door, or in places like a private study. She meets you once—offers you what you wish for. Often, you can’t hope of meeting her price. But even if you could—refuse her. Likely, that will be your only encounter, Piral. I’ve only heard of someone ever meeting her—twice. Sasi, you’ve already stepped into dangerous territory, so say nothing to her next time.”

“She approaches you? [Ladies] of Noelictus, you mean?”

“No. [Ladies]. The class the world over. Royalty too, I suspect.”

Grishen’s voice was rough, and Sasi looked up at the old woman.

“What did she offer you, Grishen? She said—she said she could bring my parents back. But I couldn’t give her what she wanted.”

Piral’s face froze, and Seraphel hugged Sasi tightly. The old woman closed her eyes. She gripped the girl’s shoulder tightly and knelt to meet her eyes.

“That monster would offer it. You were brave, Sasi. And believe me—it wouldn’t have been—*nothing* good comes from deals with Belavierr. Nothing. As for what she offered me—she came to me when I was sixty. She offered me youth, all the second chances we foolish women want. Dreams. She always offers you the worst thing, the thing you *want* if she knows it.”

Youth. Beauty. Seraphel shuddered, and now she really did see.

“Will she come to me, do you think, Grishen?”

The old [Lady] glanced up. She had heard Sasi and Seraphel recount the tale.

“Possibly. Though from what she said, she barely recognizes Calanferian royalty. It may be she doesn’t think Calanfer is old enough.”

Piral threw up her hands at that.

“*Old enough!* Fallien is right. I’m not for these tales, but I appreciate the warning. At least it seems she’s more interested in women than men. Hah! If she was offering deals to [Lords] and idiots, Terandria would have sunk into the sea long ago! Princess—Lady Sasi—let me know if that [Witch] shows her face. Until then, off I go.”

As it turned out, even her parents knew of Belavierr. When Seraphel reported her encounter—not the specifics with Sasi or the ghosts and the other oddities—she received a swift reply.

‘Stay away from her. We will take whatever steps may be taken. Do not speak to her. Offer her nothing.’

Nothing more, nothing less. Seraphel felt a chill run down her spine. Then—she settled into her routine at the Ovelian Keep.

Oh, she was jumpy for days after that with Sasi and tried not to leave her or Culin’s side. But after nigh on a week of fighting, she was used to the Hammer of Ovela *thumping* in her sleep.

Used to a routine far less pleasant than Menorome—aside from the children. So it balanced itself, or perhaps Seraphel found a new way to keep from growing mad.

Here was her routine. It went—Fallien in the mornings, breakfasting with him and his squabbling sister and hearing news of the war, arguments with the ghosts, and then they headed out to battle. The rest of the day was filled with Culin and Sasi or trying to make sense of the keep, writing to Cara—managing and speaking to Elena—and it was rather pleasant.

Then came dinner, Lord Fallien, and often, Seraphel would rise after he fell into a deep, exhausted slumber from the day’s toils.

So—nightmare, pleasantness, nightmare, sleep.

Not a bad nightmare, even. She'd had worse, and regardless of what her mother thought, she could act well enough in bed or socializing with him that he seemed to think she was happy enough.

Seraphel grew into the habit of walking late at night and taking intermittent baths. Fallien was a reasonable man. He was also young enough that they were sexually intimate at least once a day. Sometimes he would come back, go racing out as his followers made ribald jokes and his sister insulted him from the side.

Seraphel was only glad Culin, at least, was oblivious to it all, and everyone else was mostly just silent.

It was a [Princess]' duty. And again, it was usually quick, and she fooled Fallien into thinking she at least enjoyed it. But a ghost Seraphel became, again and again.

At least one person noticed her change of mood. Ser Dalimont often had Mariel, Thistel and the Thronebearers dancing attendance on her as soon as the Twins left the keep. But she didn't want much from them—and dismissed him to perform his duties.

What few they were, really. Now that she was married—he'd either be reassigned or serve her as long as she needed or until he or she tired of it and a new group of Thronebearers and servants came to her aid.

If anything, Seraphel might ask him to become her own personal [Knight], and it would confer on him a little authority. Prestige at being the 4th Princess' 'champion'—and possibly a chance for promotion in time.

She just didn't know if he actually wanted to live in Noelictus, following her around. She hoped...he did.

He was not a poor [Knight]. Well, he wasn't good at fighting, but he, like her, had changed since Afiele. The sense he was just 'doing his duty' was gone, and he did seem concerned about her and Cara, and she found Dalimont was more interesting in the Ovelian Keep.

For one thing, he had begun training with Fallien's men—and with the ghosts in private!

The sight of Ser Dalimont out of armor, retreating as he tried to fend off a spirited attack by the ghost with the halberd, made her giggle uncontrollably, and Seraphel only stopped laughing when she saw how embarrassed he looked.

“Your Highness—”

“Don't begrudge him, Princess of Calanfer. He fights well—for a young man who's not seen his first war.”

Mustrec had agreed to teach a number of people eager to learn from him. He was not using a sword—but to see Dalimont being pressed by the lazy ghost, Seraphel had to assume it was a lesson enough.

“I'm ashamed to admit it, Your Highness, Sir Mustrec, but I am a poor example of a [Knight], even for modern times. Thronebearers...are not thought of as the best. In fact, we might be tied for worst with the Order of Haegris.”

“Come now, Ser Dalimont. You look good at, er, swordplay. I've seen Thronebearers sparring in courts.”

The ghost, Mustrec, coughed, and Seraphel's attempts at boosting Dalimont's prestige backfired. The [Knight] hung his head.

“If you will allow me the chance, I will at least train to improve.”

“*That's the spirit!* You have potential, lad. Come, and let's not slack off. If your [Princess] laughing at you can weaken your arms, you'll be in trouble when you fight your first Troll alone! Their breath could knock the wind out of you—”

Back Dalimont went, and Seraphel watched until he got sent sprawling by one of Mustrec's blows. Well, at least he was doing something.

And to be fair, the Thronebearers *were* making themselves useful. Lord Fallien and Lady Piral had assessed the capabilities of her bodyguards and politely refrained from getting them killed in the fighting...and also because they would not have been much of an asset compared to Ovela's experienced troops.

However, the Twins came back one day to find three men and women from their staff in chains. Much to their delight, once Dame Neranthei showed them evidence all three were spies.

"Your Thronebearers are good at covert actions? *That's* a boon! Fallien, I'd have made you marry into Calanfer years ago if we knew that! How do they...catch [Rogues]?"

Piral was skeptical as Dame Neranthei's armor was spotless, and she was about as stealthy as a glowing lantern at midnight. But the Thronebearer just bowed to Piral.

"Bookkeeping, Lady Piral. We have gone through the staff's pay ledgers, and one member of staff was considerably richer than his wages indicated. In addition, we spotted another sneaking about the keep when she was on her break. The last was simply sending [Messages] out every time they left the keep so your [Battlemages] didn't notice."

"And you saw all that? How?"

"We watch."

What *was* a Thronebearer to do all day other than watch? They stood at attention, and many people took them to be stupid [Knights] waiting for their [Princess] to sneeze so they could fetch out a handkerchief. Or a genteel [Knight] who'd buy a round for everyone and sit there.

Listening.

Well, Seraphel also happened to know that her [Knights] were putting down ward spells, even doing things like counting how many times someone used

a gate, searching for hidden caches, or identifying bits of suspicious magic around.

That made Fallien and Piral happy, and it seemed like between keeping Baron Digneral's spies at bay and training, they too were levelling up.

Seraphel was the useless one. Seraphel was the ghost—and one of the ghosts did notice her changing condition.

Culin and Sasi did need lessons, and Seraphel was no great tutor. Calanfer hired tutors, and so did Grishen, so Seraphel had just made baked almond bars with Culin and Sasi, and she was washing off her hands.

Then she stood there, staring at nothing, and waiting for the children to finish their lesson. Seraphel walked aimlessly around the inner keep—she avoided the study, and the [Servants] bowed to her when they saw her.

“Your Majesty.”

“Can I get anything for Your Highness...?”

“Does Your Majesty want—?”

They didn't even know how to address her. Seraphel wasn't too interested in having them trained up, either. She knew her older sisters whipped a household into order, but what was the point?

Fallien is likely to let me go to Menorome or Afiele soon. When I do, I can have a smaller household. Though he may want me to be close.

Did Aielef actually arrange with her husband to have an open marriage? Or does she just cheat on him and expect him to do the same? I bet she arranged it. Fallien will have to grow tired of me. Maybe he'll be loyal.

Did men ever lose that interest in sex? Not her first two husbands... Seraphel heard more servants greeting her. Mariel and Thistel normally stopped them from bothering her, but they were cleaning up the cooking

mess. Mariel was rapidly showing her new class' worth. Culin *loved* the free box of sweets she could conjure up. It wasn't always sweets, either. Sometimes it was just a spicy little snack of baked nuts mixed with a dip, or dried pieces of fruit.

It was not the most earth-shattering Skill ever, but on the other hand...*she could create a box of free snacks every single day*. Far more valuable than Seraphel. Seraphel hadn't levelled up aside from getting married. Again. That was a [Princess] thing to do.

"Your Majesty."

"Your Highness Marquin."

"Ser Knight."

...What was that last one? Seraphel turned and nearly *leapt* out one of the windows.

Ser Dalius, the ghost, was walking behind her. He grabbed for her before she could tumble out the window, and Dame Neranthei rushed forwards to grab her.

"I am terribly sorry, Your Highness—"

"I—not at all! I just didn't see you!"

The ghost's hands were *cold*, but not freezing, and he let go and bowed.

"I apologize. I was hoping I could take some of your time, Your Highness. But you seemed lost in thought. May I speak? I once again apologize profusely for my discourtesy."

"Of course. Is Culin—?"

Dalius smiled.

"Someone else is watching over him. Fear not, Your Highness."

“You may call me Seraphel, Ser Dalius. That is—we know each other decently well, and you are Cara’s friend. How can I help you?”

Dalius offered her a slow bow, his ancient armor twining with vines and flowers, and he looked at Seraphel once before averting his eyes.

“You simply seemed bored, Your Highness. I wondered if conversation might spark your spirits. I am a humble [Knight] of older Noelictus, but if you should ever care for company, I would be happy to fill the hours of the night conversing.”

He had noticed her walking around at night. Seraphel turned red—and then realized that of all people—the ghost had no judgment. His eyes were sympathetic, and Seraphel held out a hand.

“Thank you, Ser Dalius. You know, I have never spoken to you one-on-one, despite our mutual friend in Cara. I suppose it was company. Culin does love his questions of Dragons and such.”

“I believe I’ve told him about fighting Ogres a hundred times. If I am odious—”

“Not at all. You know, I never did ask—the Order of Shadowed Blooms is defunct—I’m sorry, that is rude.”

Dalius shook his head with only the moment’s pause of sadness.

“Not at all, Your Highness. We were always a small Order, and if I may be honest, in hindsight, we were declining even when I was a member. I was one of the better [Knights] in my Order, which shows you how we were no longer at full strength. The tradition of [Knights] remains—that gives me hope.”

She began walking with him, and suddenly Seraphel was interested again, ironically in the presence of that ghost.

“What...may I ask what the Order of Shadowed Blooms did? What was their speciality? Most Orders have a theme, like the Order of Seasons and

their auras and Spring Knights and so on.”

“Those showoffs are still around?”

Dalius huffed, and Serphel blinked and then covered a smile.

“Are they—objectionable to you?”

“Only insofar that if the Order of Shadowed Blooms were to fall, *they* should—no, that would be crass of me. Of course they survived. Not every [Knight] Order gets to camp in the ruins of a half-Elven fortress. I apologize. They were always slightly smug to us, Your Highness. My Order was, as you may guess, often affiliated with motifs of nature and flowers, and the Order of Seasons used to claim they watered and fed our blooming [Knights] with their precious weather powers.”

He rolled his eyes.

“Nevermind that the [Druids] my Order was friendly with hated them for causing the weather to run amok. I was never much for the spirit of the Order, but I practiced a few humble crafts. One of my flower arrangements once won great praise from a Drathian...[Princess] I think was her class, or the equivalent thereof. But that was my finest creation.”

“*You arrange flowers?*”

She was astonished—and Ser Dalius smiled wanly.

“Arrange, not grow, Your Highness. My creations were called ‘technical’, ‘logical’, and ‘pattern-focused’ by the Guildmistress. None of those were compliments. Have you not heard of [Knights] taking up the arts?”

“Yes, but—that is so *incredible!* Not many [Knights] are that finely gifted. Why, Thronebearers can sing, dance, debate—but few of them have that level of skill. I know a Ser Lormel that my youngest sister loves because he can cook very well, but that’s all.”

“Hmm. The arts were always cultivated in my day. Dame Arteis eschews art and fought without end most of her life, but a [Knight] could level by

pursuing their own virtuous arts. Speaking of which—may I trouble you, Princess Seraphel, to ask about other Knight Orders still extant? I would bother Ser Dalimont, but I fear he dislikes me. Possibly we have a similar name and Lord Fallien keeps confusing the two of us?”

Seraphel shook her head at once.

“You intimidate him. I believe he compares himself to you and finds himself wanting in any regard.”

“Really? I’m not much.”

So said the [Knight] who had cut down an undead giant and known Dragons, or at least been in their times. Dalius was self-effacing where Arteis was not, and he hesitated.

“This Order of Haegris he mentioned...?”

“Oh, Hagggle-Knights. They’re a funny lot.”

“*Hagggle-Knights*? What do they do?”

Like that, Seraphel found she had a friend in the Ovelian Keep. Ser Dalius was the first male friend she’d had...

Well, ever, probably. [Knights] sworn to protect her didn’t count, and a [Princess] had to be careful with any man she talked with in a friendly way.

But Dalius was dead. And it turned out the dead had a lot to say.

Lord Fallien hardly begrudged Seraphel talking with a ghost. Indeed, he seemed rather relieved when she brought up Dalius being her companion.

Perhaps he’d also been wondering how loyal his bride-of-convenience might be. Well, Seraphel had given no one any time in Menorome, and she hadn’t really intended on that kind of thing.

But Dalius was a freedom from even that issue. He made Seraphel's own sickheartedness become far less of an issue, much to her people's relief.

"You're eating again, Your Highness."

"I always eat, Thistel."

Seraphel shot back after two days over a meal as Ser Dalius placed flowers he'd found outside the Ovelian keep into a vase. Culin and Sasi were watching as the [Knight] adjusted their position.

"You would bend them, you see, and have a variety. Even wires to hold them in place. This is simple, Lady Sasi—"

"It's so pretty, Ser Dalius! Do you have a Skill? Oh...I heard you had none. I'm sorry."

Dalius visibly brightened and shook his head.

"It turns out that was another gift, a small ritual that I was never taught to restore my abilities. Once again, Arteis taught me how to regain my power. I am ten times the warrior I was, both in combat and culture. I should not be using them frivolously, but—"

He winked.

"—Just a small one that we shall keep secret, eh? [Flowers, Smile for Me]."

And each one winked open, the closed buds of wilting fall flowers turning bright and vibrant. Even for gloomy Noelictus—there was more than a hint of color as he arranged them, creating a checkerwork pattern.

"Your Highness?"

"...I can see why you were called technically competent, Ser Dalius."

She couldn't resist the jibe, and his face fell. Seraphel ignored Culin and Sasi booing her.

“Oh come now! He’s just alternating colors! Culin, don’t you dare, young man! Don’t throw your napkin at me!”

However, she laughed, and she finished eating, and Thistel sighed in relief. Seraphel rolled her eyes at the notion she had ever been underfed. Though she had to admit, she had noticed she was looking slim, even by her mother’s standards, in the mirror for a bit. But that was the eternal difficulty of [Princesses], and her [Maids] should have been cheering her on. Usually, to lose weight, Seraphel needed a dieting tonic from an [Alchemist].

The benefits of talking with Ser Dalius was more than just comparing their times, though. Seraphel realized she truly *wasn’t* like what he’d expected when they were touring the battlements.

Ser Dalimont was marching ahead of them, and there was no danger of an attack; it seemed the Twins had razed one of Digneral’s camps, and so they were winning today—good moods in Lord Fallien and Piral compared to when they were spitting curses and arguing after a loss.

“You know, Your Highness Seraphel, I am grateful I worked up the nerve to ask if you would speak. Calanfer must be a wonderful place.”

“Oh? How do you picture the Eternal Throne?”

She smiled, and Dalius, who had never heard it actually described, or knew the secret of what it really was, gave it considerable thought.

“I should imagine it’s a place of sunshine and light. Of frank, informally social folk, and the [Kings] who’d walk into a tavern and drink with the common folk and wrestle pigs in the mud. Like Eribatthe, the Kingdom of Myths, which I’m assured still exists.”

Seraphel and Dalimont began laughing at the idea, and Dalius raised his brows.

“No?”

“You have sunshine and light, but the rest? Oh, Ser Dalius! You are a jokester. Calanfer is the famous kingdom of diplomats! We’re considered the best socialites, and my father wrestling a pig? He might go into a tavern, but he’s the most traditional [King] you might meet! King Itreimedes of Avel is far better suited to your description!”

Avel had been around when Dalius was alive, and he frowned deeply.

“Truly? I can’t speak to each [King], but I thought you were the most... informal [Princess] I’ve ever met. You’re so down-to-earth and casual. Your parlance, Seraphel, is practically like any other commoner’s I grew up with as a boy.”

Ser Dalimont turned his head as Seraphel’s mouth opened. She and he stared at Dalius as he gave her an earnest smile, thinking he was complimenting her. Dalimont kept walking, hit the edge of the battlements, and actually went *over* them.

“Dead gods! He’s fallen off the—”

“Someone save the [Knight]!”

Seraphel rushed over to the battlements and saw Dalimont lying thirty feet below, groaning. Then she turned.

“Me? Informal?”

“Dead gods! He went over that waist-high piece of stone! What was he thinking? Is he alright?”

Dalius dove down and then floated back up.

“Wait—you are incredibly informal, Your Highness. Why, you don’t even insist on your royal title, you neglect the royal ‘we’, your etiquette is completely informal, and I should have been lambasted for even approaching you without seeking an audience first. You’re completely... plebian. In a refreshing way we ghosts appreciate. The world truly is different after our sleep.”

He smiled at her. And Seraphel?

She had never been more offended in her life.

The next day, Seraphel saw off Lord Fallien. He was rushing out the door to stymie Lord Digneral.

“We’re going to dam the river up and wash half his troops away—if Pirál can keep him off us long enough.”

“Me? You’re the one who can’t stop that Mirror Knight!”

“I don’t see you rushing to challenge him—”

He was halfway out of the room when Ser Dalius politely barred his way.

“Lord Fallien, I don’t believe it’s customary even in this age to forget saying a word to—your wife?”

“Oh. Right. ”

Fallien stared at Dalius, then, flustered, he looked over at Seraphel.

“I’m sorry, Seraph—what happened to your hair?”

The [Princess] was sitting up in her chair as Sasi, Thistel, and several members of the keep admired her. Her red hair, the same color as wine or the starburst of sun as evening fell, was dotted with flowers.

She’d arranged it herself and had long gloves that laced up just below the elbows on, white, with the faintest indentations visible. Her dress was a summer’s green, and she looked like a flower-[Princess]. She had put on makeup with Mariel’s help, and she made both Fallien and Pirál turn and stare.

When she tried, a [Princess] could make a splash. Even her wedding attire hadn’t stood out as much. Seraphel turned her head, and her smile struck

Fallien just above the heart.

“Lady Piral, Fallien. I wish you success in battle.”

“Er—thank you.”

Both of them bowed, and Dalius snorted softly. Seraphel turned red.

“It’s a good attempt, but everything you do is still...”

“If you say commonfolk, I will find a way to hit you. I have been trained by the world’s finest [Queen] in the art of—sitting and looking dignified!”

“...Maybe. I doubt Drath would agree, even today. It still exists, right?”

Dalius and Seraphel quarreled—or rather, she got mad and he was making something. She stomped around him, and he fiddled with some cloth, wood slats, and fletcher’s glue.

“There is no way you can make something that will ‘enhance my image’ with that. It stinks. You’re using scraps of wood and old dresses of mine.”

“Dignity is in how you use it, not how you speak. *Thees and thous* are part of the art, Your Royal Highness. You employ it like someone who knows the steps of a dance, but not *why* you dance.”

She lifted a trembling finger.

“I shall have Halberdier Mustrec teach you a lesson, Dalius. Ghosts can hit other ghosts. Either prove your words or—”

He unfolded the parasol he’d made, and Seraphel stopped. The [Knight] had carved a central hole for a piece of wood, and if he pushed, the slats of wood placed in a circle *opened* and the cloth he’d layered over the parasol stretched.

He'd made...a parasol. With his bare hands and scraps! Dame Neranthei choked. Seraphel stared as each color—from old dresses—spiraled around as Dalius twirled it. It may not have been the finest coordination of color—but it was a pattern that gently shifted from color to color.

Dalius spun the parasol, then shaved a bit of wood off the handle. He stood straight and tall and looked at her.

“This is how you stand. Your posture is good, and if I give you this parasol, you hold it. Perhaps you can twirl it and look fine aesthetically.”

He mimed the motion. Then the [Knight of Shadowed Blooms] shook his head.

“But I did see the [Princess] of Noelictus, once, holding a parasol from Drath in the crook of one arm as she sat on the steps of the Palace of Twilight, playing a harp to greet the dawn. A [Painter] saw her there and locked himself in his study for four days and nights without eating to capture the artwork. You should look for it if you visit the palace.”

“Anyone can move a [Painter] to ooze all over a canvas.”

Seraphel managed a reply. Dalius raised his brows.

“Really? You show me how you'd do it. Then I'll copy her.”

Seraphel took the parasol and felt like a proper fool as she tried to put on the most sensual and elegant pose. Thistel tried not to smile; Dalius covered his mouth, and she glared.

She realized he often did hide his smile or laughter with a hand. He took the parasol back—and then closed it.

“Well? I'm waiting for your fancy pose.”

She had tried to stretch out, one knee raised, parasol resting along her neck as she turned her head back and then to the side, like a model posing for the unseen viewer. Dalius was still standing like a tall statue, and she was about to lay into him. But then the [Knight] adjusted how he stood, turned—

...It was about how you walked, after all. No, it wasn't just that.

Ielane was a master of form. She had instilled perfect posture into her children, and they could easily bow to a [Marquis] and to a [Duke], and tell you what the difference in how deeply you inclined your head was, or find the nuances in a single step, a flicker of an eye, and more.

However, Dalius' movements were also refined, but they were accompanied by something that Seraphel realized she had never trained.

And that was emotion. He stood as the parasol twirled, balanced upon one finger, then snatched it down and strolled forwards. Thistel caught her breath, and Seraphel thought she could almost see it.

If she had seen him walking like that down the Eternal Throne's streets, petals of flowers falling behind him, on a day of autumn, she would have had her breath taken away. He looked around, panning his head slowly, and more than his admittedly good looks, more than the twirling parasol of colors, his posture—

He seemed at *peace*. And that—

That was what they called grace.

Every [Prince] and [Princess] of Terandria would have hesitated if they had to go up in a war for style with Ser Dalius.

Not that he was perfect. He turned, blushed when he saw Thistel and Seraphel staring, and lowered the parasol sheepishly.

“That was showing off, wasn't it? Cara would tear me to shreds if she saw me try it. She knows the trick I'm badly pulling off. To tell you the truth, I'm embarrassed that I never showed her my better side.”

“You...I never knew you could do *that!*”

He exhaled softly.

“Cara found me after centuries...longer, I fear, of isolation. I went truly mad for a while. I was arranging mouse bones into piles by the end of it—then I just sat. The first hundred years I counted, I kept myself sane by sitting and meditating. After that, I just counted mice. But only now have I regained some of my—composure and talents besides swinging a sword.”

He gave her a rueful smile.

“You have reminded me a [Knight] is more than a blade, Your Highness. We did learn how to perform admirably at court. As I said—you are a delightful [Princess]. Just not the most refined one I’ve ever met.”

“Would you—teach me how to do that?”

She bit her lip. She hated to admit it, but Dalius had a knowledge of both foreign etiquette—like Drathian customs, something even Calanfer struggled with—and flower arrangement and more. He was surprised.

“I am not that—”

“Oh, shut up. I am considered a very good dancer in Calanfer. If you can out-dance me—I’ll wager Noelictus’ old styles are far different than now.”

He hesitated as Thistel clapped her hands, and he coughed.

“It would be unseemly—oh, wait. I am dead, and you’re plebian. Very well. I did used to know a magical dance, even if I could only pull it off one in a thousand times.”

“A...magical dance?”

Ser Dalius laughed then. Until he realized she and Thistel truly had no idea what he was talking about.

“A dance that conjures magic. *Your Highness*. You can joke with me, but—you are joking, right? Do you people not even know how to dance? A child could do it.”

She put her hands on her hips since she couldn't kick him in the shins. Seraphel looked at Dalius and held out a hand.

“Show me?”

Dalimont knew what she was doing.

Mariel knew what was in her mistress' heart. Dead gods, most of the Calanferians noticed. If Grishen did—well, Culin and Sasi didn't see Seraphel as much with Dalius, and Culin only complained that Dalius wasn't always by his side.

Dalimont didn't say anything for a long time. It wasn't as if Seraphel was doing anything wrong.

Was it wrong to learn how to dance from a ghost? Even Ielane would have admitted that Ser Dalius could have taken the floor with her Thronebearers.

“Did they do *everything* better back in the day?”

“Say rather, we were all born in a time before these Creler Wars ravaged your world, Your Highness. When you have a Vault of Evergrowth that feeds folk, a [Farmer] has the time to learn to dance. When the Dancer of Izril could charm even Dragons, of course everyone learns a magical dance. She was barely fifteen when I died of sickness, and they already called her the talent of the age. I fear the Creler Wars broke out soon after that, you know.”

“*Really?*”

Dalius had never dated his death before, but the [Knight] had been using books and consulting with Dalimont, who had queried Calanfer's libraries. He exhaled.

“The Dancer of Izril died in the Creler Wars when they broke out. Your records go back just around then—and though they are incomplete, my Knight Order was one that perished in the war, along with much of

Noelictus. The palace destroyed. Ghosts...I wonder *why* they did not rise. Something may have been wrong, even then. But I remember Rhir's hell as being fallow, untended. Arteis remembers a great foe there. The Infernal Court she battled against."

"Dead gods. So you're six thousand years old. At least! Wait, noble houses colonizing...you might have been over ten *thousand* years old! Fourteen thousand!"

Dalius looked pained.

"I wish I had not died of plague. I would have been able to fight—! No, if I was that far removed, perhaps I could have simply made them more ready for what was to come. To hear you speak of it, that was a threat every hand was needed for. Alas, I woke as a ghost and sat in my tomb without knowing a war was going on."

They were stepping around, and he was showing her a pattern so complicated Seraphel, used to memorizing routines, kept messing up.

"And a child could do this?"

"If they wanted to learn—yes. And any child who sees this dance will want to do it. You underestimate children, Seraphel. Ah, the Dancer!"

He closed his eyes, saddened. Seraphel glanced up at him.

"I don't remember her from my history of the Creler Wars. You never met her."

"No, but I saw pictures. A few things your world has in this age are—mage-pictures, better [Scrying] spells, and healing potions. They were so rare even a [Knight] like myself wouldn't have access to one easily."

"*Really.*"

He nodded soberly.

“Sickness after being wounded or bleeding out killed many [Knights] I knew. I was astonished when I learnt how common they are. That alone makes this time better—but the *Dancer*. I am just sad to hear of it, Seraphel. You know, she went to Rhir to fight and died there.”

“That’s...tragic. She was no fighter.”

“No. But her death galvanized many nations to fight when they were watching their borders. I read that the Dragonlords, the last four, flew to Rhir to honor her. The Dragonlords of War, Wind, Flame, and Sea. Even the Silver Knight of Byres. The world seems smaller, sometimes, now you say there are no more Giants, no more Dragons flying left and right.”

“There are Demons on Rhir.”

He nodded, eyes lost in age and memory.

“Then perhaps there’s still evil the likes of which Arteis fought. I should like to see them.”

She shuddered and, even now, felt a chill akin to Belavierr’s presence run down her back.

“You are a brave man—likely because you have no body left to lose, Ser Dalius. The Demon King and his Deaths...are the most terrifying entities held back only by the Blighted Kingdom. If there is a war anywhere worthy of you and your ghosts, it would be them.”

He stopped, and she nearly walked *through* him a second.

“Yes. That *would* be a use for us. Arteis has demanded some of us go from the first day. But I—this war with Ailendamus is against a nation I do not know. Skirmish, rather, but we have been thinking—arguing—about what to do.”

She looked up at him in the private room they were using to practice and blinked.

“You’ve been arguing?”

“Nonstop. What, do you think we were immune to the suffering of Ovela? But we are wary of repeating the follies of old Noelictus—and yet the Twins are laboring against that Baron. He is...a more dangerous man than I was in life. We *are* sworn to Noelictus as well as Afiele. But there is a question, to me at least, where to spend our might.”

Dalius confessed his worries, and Seraphel bit her lip.

“You would be a fearsome army on the field, Ser Dalius. But I do not think that is what you wish to be.”

“Arteis is the warrior eternal. I? I know ghosts can die. Magic nearly ended me at the Tomb of Afiele—we are not immortal. But we should—*must*—spend our lives well. I am the authority, it seems, but Arteis is my senior and a greater ghost. So—I am heeding her words too. What do you think we should do?”

Seraphel lifted her hands and laughed sadly.

“Dalius—I don’t even know what *I* should do. I just got married, and I’ve fulfilled my duties. I am a silly, plebian [Princess]. You have no constraints upon you.”

He looked at her and touched her cheek—then drew away.

“Only honor and duty and rightness, Your Highness.”

“Ah. Well. Besides that, I mean.”

He turned away, troubled, and she felt her heart fluttering as Thistel watched. Then Dalius took her hand, and they stepped across the ground—and Dame Neranthei, and the servants of Calanfer looked on.

“Fine, it’s more gracious than even the courts back home. I’ve never seen...”

Mariel whispered, her voice torn as they stepped across the floor. Thistel just looked at Seraphel and Dalius. She was wiping at her eyes. As if seeing

something better than the Eternal Throne captured in the faint blue light of the [Knight] and the black dress the [Princess] wore.

Shadows and light, swirling on the floor, leaving a trail of faint dancing light that opened like blossoms. The [Maid] whispered.

“It’s beautiful.”

[Gloomy Princess Level 20!]

[Skill – Shadow Step learned!]

[Skill – Dance of the Midnight Blooms obtained!]

Then came blood and fire. Then the Baron of Ailendamus pushed over the river with three fresh battalions, and Seraphel was reminded Ovela was at war.

She saw him for the first time, the [Baron of the Mirror Lands], as she stood on Ovela’s Keep. The Hammer of Ovela roared, again and again, but the thing she had taken for granted, thunder and fury from the skies—

It couldn’t hold him back.

He was astride a stallion of his own, surrounded by [Soldiers] bearing those bright, polished-mirror shields. They advanced, and she saw the man who could hold back the Twins.

Not just hold back, even—Piral reached him as Fallien’s vanguard broke through Ailendamus’ center. They were being enfolded on both sides in a way even the [Princess] could see.

Drell Knights, armored in glass. Crossbows snapping, and Ovelian men and women falling left and right as those Greatbows tore up the ground.

She was sick—Culin and Sasi were below, forbidden from seeing it.

“And this is how Ovela’s been fighting? For six years?”

The horror-struck [Princess] turned her head, unable to believe this was the state of Ailendamus and Noelictus. However, Grishen replied steadily.

“It is not. This is the Baron playing his full hand. It’s gone the Twins’ way most of the time. This is a slaughter.”

Ser Dalimont was observing the battle as Neranthei held up a shield, on the off-chance an arrow reached the battlements from there.

“They’ve nearly reached the Baron. If they can kill him, his army may fold. His Skills empower the troops. Those shields, his authority—all stem from his class and levels. If he dies—”

Grishen growled.

“If. Piral and Fallien are considered the two best halberd-users in Noelictus. Ghost Mustrec, how do you rate the Baron compared to our Twins?”

They all turned to the old [Royal Halberdier]. The old man was tellingly silent. He spoke slowly, tugging at his ghostly beard.

“The Twins are fierce, talented children. Yonder lies a better fighter than I.”

He pointed—and Seraphel’s heart sank as they reached Digneral.

It wasn’t a duel. For one thing, Fallien and Piral were jostling to get at him. One would charge in with their personal troops, and the other would flank their assault. They tried to coordinate—but Digneral’s troops rushed to defend him.

Piral got there first, though, and her halberd swung down with crushing force—and *bounced* off Digneral’s mirror-shield. He riposted, his blade slashing across her armor so fast it cut through the enchanted mail.

Fallien was next. He leapt *up*, and Seraphel heard Dalimont whisper.

“[Bravery’s Leap]. [Untargetable Leader]. [Thunderous Blow]—”

No arrows were aimed up at Fallien, and the [Baron] set himself. When the blow fell on him, his horse screamed, and he went over.

“Yes!”

Ovela cheered as Fallien dropped him—but the [Baron] had sent Fallien flying with a blow of his own. The [Lord] rolled, engulfed by the fighting, and Piral charged back in to finish the deed. Seraphel saw the [Baron] rise, and his sword gleamed—

“Oh no.”

She heard the roar of sound and then silence. And the [Baron] shook blood off his blade as the Twins faltered. The ghosts stared at Ser Dalius, and Dame Arteis ground her teeth.

“This is Noelictus’ might? *Ser Dalius!*”

“Not yet.”

“I can abide no longer!”

The ghosts quarreled, and Dalius hesitated. Digneral was routing Ovela. His forces fell on the fleeing [Soldiers] as the Twins scrambled back in full retreat.

Digneral

The [Thunderous Blow] from the leaping Lord Fallien knocked him flat. He tasted blood and dirt in his mouth as he landed on the ground.

“*Got him! Piral!*”

They fought well together. Two Level 30+ nobles. But foolishly. He hadn’t expected the [Lord] to *leap* like that. He could have been speared as he came down, and they had hit his vanguard and sacrificed their army to do it.

He had nothing but contempt for their self-serving styles. Ovela was poor because they couldn’t do more than war.

—*But he had forgotten they were still dangerous.* Digneral rose as she came a-hunting, unmounted, her halberd spinning up.

“This is your end, Digneral!”

Piral screamed. Frustration in her voice from weeks of being bested by his slow advance and a real force of Ailendamus pushing into their lands. Small wonder the capital hadn’t put the army into her hands.

He had hoped they would, and [Hunters] too. If so, he had been ready to bleed Noelictus of their best. They made much of the Hunter’s Guild—

Piral was coming. Digneral was ready. He lifted his sword, and he had more than one Skill to use—but contempt? *Ah*, yes. He had the perfect thing to teach the Twins a lesson.

“[Copy Skill: Thunderous Blow].”

He swung it right back at her. All of her brother’s might—and more.

Thunderclap. He saw Piral hit the ground as his ears stopped ringing from the force of their blades meeting. She rolled, and he would have captured her or finished her off, but he’d sent her straight back at her forces.

“Dead gods! He’s—”

Fallien was getting up, woozy, and Digneral checked his mount. The poor animal was down, possibly with broken bones from the crash.

“Healing potion. Reform your lines.”

His bodyguard surrounded him. Digneral mounted a second steed as Fallien and Piral hesitated. He half-hoped they’d charge, but they did the smart thing.

“[Mark Target]! Fire the Hammer of Ovela!”

Fallien howled, and Digneral looked up. He heard the *thunderclap* in the distance and saw a distant object shake. Then—seconds later—

A stake came hurtling down at him from the skies. This was the terror of Ailendamus' soldiers and why he had failed so long to take Ovela completely.

Mostly because he wanted the Hammer of Ovela, and if they moved it out of his range...Digneral sighed. To his bodyguard's credit, they only shifted as they saw it hurtling down on him from above.

Normally, he had barrier spells or was fighting too far for the trick to work. He'd just move out of the way. Now? Digneral was done playing games.

Time for a capstone Skill. He lifted his shield overhead and called out.

“[Bound Spell: Mirror of the Heavens]!”

Piral stared at him. She had *never* seen him use this Skill. She thought she had his measure. He heard her turn to her brother and ask.

“What did he just—”

The mirror that appeared overhead was fifteen feet tall and half as wide. It was made of whirling air and winds, and light *flashed* as it hovered in the sky. The bolt from the Hammer of Ovela *struck* it—

And it *bounced* straight into Ovela's lines.

Carnage. At this range Digneral could aim the bolt, and he sent it spinning horizontally through as many [Soldiers] as he could before it halted.

Possibly a hundred died, and he resolved this to be the last. Once Ovela was his, he would let the populace recover—and make sure they knew that they had only died like dogs due to their incompetent [Lord] and [Lady]'s pride. Doubtless, he would not be the one who ruled it.

The butcher comes before the seeds of better tomorrow. Each to their own.

“Retreat! *Get to the keep! Get to the—*”

“Run them down. Where is Knight Ouren?”

Digneral turned as the Twins fled. His soldiers tried to pursue, but the Twins were good at running. His [Strategist] spoke crisply into his ear via speaking stone.

“He awaits your command, sir!”

“Good! Have him lead the Drell Knights into the keep when the Twins retreat into it. Move up the outriders; give them no other option.”

The Twins had truly blundered in their attack. If they’d been more cautious, they might have forced him back. But they’d only sped up the timetables on what he considered his final attack; if his [Knights] held the gates long enough, the siege would be over in a flash.

Digneral’s army advanced as a column of fresh Drell Knights charged, led by Ser Ouren. The Mirror Knight had the same abilities as Digneral; the ability to reflect spells, even copy abilities.

Digneral was higher-level, but serving under him had made the young champion level faster than even Digneral could dream of. He was surging towards the keep, and Digneral watched as his troops ran down the Ovelians too slow to retreat.

Blood ran into the ground as his [Crossbowmen] shot down black-armored figure after figure. Piral’s riders were fleeing ahead of Fallien’s infantry, and his own non-[Knight] riders were cutting them down from behind.

No surrender, no quarter. Not for the final blow. Digneral abhorred the waste...but he would have rather killed both Twins.

Once I take the keep, it will be either war—or a tenuous peace. Either way, he would be receiving the favor of the crown and a new order to push Noelictus to the brink. Digneral had faith Noelictus had more fangs, and Ailendamus’ war machine might need to send even one of their Great Generals to defend—

But the Hammer of Ovela will make this province as difficult for the Kingdom of Shade to retake as it was for my forces to claim. Harder; it will

not be managed by two incompetents.

His plans had been reviewed by Ailendamus' best [Strategists]. He had even timed this battle such that the surrounding forces, if they chose to intervene, would run into delaying forces.

He'd heard Princess Seraphel was at the keep. Digneral had ordered her, and the two children of Afiele—*children in a warzone!*—spared at all costs.

The Baron had planned it all. The one thing he had not accounted for was rumors. He had heard of Afiele's salvation.

...But he did not believe in ghosts. The few reports that the damned Thronebearers had allowed from the keep had claimed they'd seen spectral figures. However, Digneral had not seen them on the battlefield.

He had suspected illusions. Tricks. [Hunters] if anything—but they had not aided the Twins until now. So he had relaxed his guard.

It never occurred to Digneral that his foes might be biding their time.

Now—a single figure arose from the walls. Pale blue, translucent, ignoring the voice that called her back. She threw back her head and donned a helmet. Then—she flew off the walls.

Digneral saw the ghost at once and hesitated, but he did not demand his forces stall.

“So these are Ovela's ghosts? Target that apparition. Crossbow Division 2. Volley one.”

They *loosed*, and he watched as bolts soared into the distance. On the walls, people took cover, but he was fascinated. *Illusion?* Why now? It wasn't slowing Ser Ouren, nor was *one* impressive.

Maybe it was a ghost. When the bolts flew, she actually held up a shield—then let the pieces of metal and wood pass through her. As if she were reflexively blocking them.

Fascinating. She descended to the ground, and the Noelictus people cried out. Maybe she *was* a ghost.

“[Battlemages]. Prepare lightning bolts. [Mages] one to fourteen. [Army: Pinpoint Spellcasting].”

He knew how to kill ghosts. Once he’d heard he might be facing them, he’d studied records and seen they died to magic. They were immune to all but silver and a few rare metals like Truegold. Even silver barely hurt them.

But magic? He admired the ghost as she began to run towards his advancing forces. She looked like some mighty [Knight] of old, and he thought he espied some more on the keep’s walls.

Good. He suspected Duke Rhisveri and many more would be interested in them if they surrendered. But Digneral felt bad for this soul, called back for a pointless war.

Then he lowered his hand, and fourteen bolts of lightning flashed through the air. They were slower than real lightning, but almost as quick.

Each one caught her, and the flash made the world vanish, even though he’d closed his eyes. Digneral opened them—

And then he got a nasty surprise.

Seraphel

She hadn’t blocked! When Arteis had landed on the ground, she’d begun running, not flying, and Seraphel had heard Dalius shouting at her to *come back*.

She had seen the [Mages] readying spells and screamed a warning. Because she had worried—the [Paladin] was facing an *army*.

“Get ready! To me—”

Dalius was roaring at Mustrec and the others, but before they could move—fourteen bolts of lightning struck Arteis.

“Arteis!”

Duchess Grishen shouted. She had been preparing to bail the Twins out. But the charging Drell Knights. The soldiers of Ovela being cut down—

Arteis. Seraphel pushed Neranthei’s hands away and looked over the battlements. The shield blocked her from seeing the [Baron], but the ghost was below. She looked down with dread—

Paladin Arteis Ladel had halted. She had not blocked or raised her shield. Now—she raised her lowered head. Her teeth were gritted, and she exhaled with slow, measured force.

“I thought so. The times change. It isn’t [Grand Lightning]. Dalius. They have no force.”

She was *unharm*ed. The [Paladin] raised her sword, and Dalius looked over the walls incredulously. Mustrec shook his head as he adjusted his armor.

“[Spell Resistance]. She’s exaggerating. I have fought in Noelictus’ name in death, Tombwarden. We shall have to be warier.”

“Then we sally from the earth! Let her strike the first blow—”

Dalius was cursing. The [Knight] nodded as the other ghosts lifted their blades.

“We have no choice! Let her strike the first blow and follow me! To the ground!”

They vanished into the ground, and Seraphel’s head whirled to Dalimont’s. The Thronebearer was wide-eyed, and they looked over the battlements.

The ghosts had finally taken Ovela’s side. A hush had fallen around those who had seen Arteis take the lightning bolts, but the Ailendamus [Soldiers] began to attack again. They clearly thought she was an illusion.

“Open the gates! Open the gates!”

Swords were cutting down Ovela's troops from behind. Seraphel was sick at seeing the blood running. She had survived a siege of the dead—and this was worse. This was people killing people.

It was what had moved Arteis at last. The [Paladin] began to run once more. She passed *through* flinching [Soldiers]. Heading straight for Ailendamus' lines.

“To arms, Afiele! Shake, foes of Noelictus! For the Kingdom of Shade—and dawn always comes in the darkest of days!”

She lifted her sword overhead as she raised her ancient shield. The first [Swordsman] who saw her was charging in a column at a bunch of [Archers] he had been cutting down from behind. He raised an enchanted blade and slashed as Arteis charged at him.

The blade *glanced* off her armor. Seraphel gasped. Arteis leapt at him—and ran the man through. She transitioned from a jump into *flight*, and her blade passed his armored chest, cutting steel mail, flesh, and coming out the other side.

But unlike his blade—hers was covered in blood. It spurted out the other side as she passed *through* him. Then—impaled the [Soldier] running behind him, the ones slowing—piercing their chests without slowing.

“—What?”

Dame Neranthei, a [Knight] who had seen battle, blinked down and almost lowered her shield. Seraphel covered her mouth.

It was so fast that it looked like she'd missed. Some of Ailendamus' soldiers were actually laughing. Until they saw the [Swordsman] falling, a hole in his chest.

Six men and women died. Arteis slowed, landed, and a blade flickered through where her heart should have been. A spear. She walked towards the terrified woman who'd jabbed her. This time—she swung her sword horizontally.

A head fell from a torso. Blood. Arteis shook it from her sword.

More lightning. And flames. A [Fireball] arced down—and Arteis blocked it on a shield. Two bolts struck her in the chest, and she grunted. She didn't so much as take a step back. She whirled her blade up—and cut a ball of flames in half.

The halves exploded around her, and the Twins slowed. The Drell Knights turned, aborting their charge on the keep. Seraphel saw Arteis halt.

“I am Paladin Arteis Ladel of the Dawn Patrol! Ghost of Noelictus! Sworn defender of Afiele's fields! Yield or perish! I give you no second quarter!”

Her voice *howled* across the battlefield, impossibly loud. The running [Soldiers] of Ailendamus turned, and Arteis rose into the sky.

Baron Digneral was staring at her. More spells rained down, but the ghost barely flinched. She was rising, now, and her blue, ghostly body was flying higher into Noelictus' dusky skies.

“Very well. Then to arms, Afiele. Tombwarden! Let us strike Noelictus' foes! Ghosts, to arms! They die!”

Then she screamed, a howl of fury, and Seraphel looked up at her and remembered how Arteis had led the charge against the dead. But this time, her wrath was far, far worse. She flew higher, into the skies.

Was she going to dive? Ailendamus' army was reforming. The Mirror Knight was pulling back, uncertain of what to do against a flying foe. Ranks of [Soldiers] stared up at her.

Perhaps they could feel it. A trembling in their blood. A terror in their veins.

That blue ghost was changing color. Her sword was first. It shone yellow, a glare of power that even death acknowledged. Then orange.

Then the sky turned orange—and brighter. Brighter. The Ovelians cried out first. Seraphel's own eyes burned. She had not seen something so bright in

her time here.

It was getting—brighter still. A glare so fierce it shone behind her closed eyes. And that was nothing to the effect it had on Arteis’ foes.

Brighter.

Then there was heat. Heat, but no flames. It shone down as the [Paladin]—*[Paladin]*—screamed. She was a burning sun. A light searing the eyes.

Rays of light burned down from the heavens, and Seraphel saw the ground catch fire. [Soldiers] shading their eyes began to scream—then their flesh began to melt. And brighter Arteis glowed. Shining as desperate men and women put up those mirror-shields. But it did nothing to protect them. She looked down at the [Baron] as he stared up at her.

“[Dawn Rises in Hell]!”

Ailendamus’ army was breaking. They were dying. Skin melting—armor turning to metal. *Flames blackened the battlefield*—and Arteis’ Skill was followed by the ghosts.

They erupted from the ground, blades cutting down mortals at the legs. Then—a [Knight] flew out of the ground and swung his sword through two [Mages] who tried to stop him.

But Ser Dalius’ blade cleaved through magic, and the ghosts were everywhere. Mustrec, the kindly man, swung his halberd, flying down and beheading [Soldiers] who tried to attack him with melting eyes—but nothing not made of magic struck him.

“Dead gods. Eternal Throne protect...”

Arteis landed as Ser Dalimont whispered. She did not look at the [Soldiers] dying or fleeing. Someone was blowing a horn—and the Twins were turning. But she just slashed a sword out.

“Hold your forces back, Fallien, Piral. This is a battle for ghosts to claim. *Who will challenge me? I am Arteis of Noelictus! Come, Ailendamus!*

Come, you champions!”

She howled, and the mortals of Ovela stopped. But a burnt, smoking warrior stumbled forwards.

“Name yourself.”

“—*Thirsting Veil*. Ser Girried.”

Arteis strode at him as the burnt [Knight] of Ailendamus’ Thirsting Veil lifted a blade. He struck twice. His blade passed through her armor. She glanced down at his sword.

“Poisoned, but unenchanted. A shame.”

He recoiled, and she lopped off his sword-arm. Then pivoted and took his helmet off at the neck. Arteis whirled.

“Next. Come, you [Knights]! I challenge thee!”

She moved forwards, and they approached slowly. [Knights] in armor, staring at this monstrous ghost. The next group did not duel her.

Three of them, two Hydra Knights, one Thirsting Veil, tried to attack her. A Skill passed through her armor—she blocked a glowing blade from one of the Hydra Knights.

“[Sword Art: Song of the Agelum].”

She cut straight through another’s armor and left only a red corpse. Arteis slashed through the Hydra Knight’s armor, and the Thirsting Veil [Knight] dropped her mace.

“We yield. We yield, Dame Ghost.”

She flipped up her visor, and Arteis halted as the Hydra Knight did the same. She glanced at the two as they sank to their knees.

“I saw you offer no quarter to Noelictus’ children. I accept no quarter, I said. You were warned.”

Her blade flashed down, and then Dalimont cried out.

“Arteis! Stop!”

Dalius whirled, but the [Paladin] just shook blood from her blade. Then she turned.

“Come at me, one or all. As you please.”

A dozen [Knights] had halted, wearing translucent glass-armor. Their leader, his armor shining like a mirror, reflected the burning flames and harsh light still shining down. His voice was young—but grating.

“I would duel you, *ghost*. But you have no honor at all.”

“I am a [Paladin] who has fought the devils of hell. I have no code to war. *Lucifen fall.*”

He didn’t know what she meant. But the Mirror Knight did dismount as the Drell Knights slowly advanced. Eleven ghosts walked forwards and spread out.

Arteis faced Ser Ouren, the Mirror Knight, on the field as he raised his sword. He stood tall, six-foot-five, a mortal hero. She regarded him, burning-eyed, without pity.

“Boy. You should have run.”

“I am a [Knight] of Ailendamus and Drell. I care not who you are, ghost.”

“No? Nor should you. Valor befits you decently. But know this:”

Arteis walked towards him, and he hesitated.

“You would have been a [Knight] without fame when I was alive.”

He died slowly. And poorly.

It was Seraphel who broke away first, covering her eyes and ears. The rest were spellbound, but she could bear to hear Knight Ouren scream no longer.

His sword and armor were enchanted. So he struck Arteis Ladel with blows that cut her essence. In reply, she tore his armor, and he bled onto the ground. Each time they clashed, he lost something of himself.

She just reformed. She had not lied to Sasi. A [Paladin] was more than a [Knight]. And she was a ghost, without blood to lose. Without a [Knight]’s modern pride.

Arteis appeared from the ground and hamstringed Ser Ouren after their first clash, when his mirror-shield made her recoil. She dove—then came up and behind, tearing through his armor in a flash.

After that—she circled as he screamed at her to stand and *fight*. She refused. At the end, she waited for him to bleed out before finishing the poor [Knight].

The other Drell Knights fared—better. Ser Dalius forced his [Knight] to surrender. The others died mercifully faster, outmatched by their opponents.

Ghosts, each over Level 40. Monsters, monsters. Seraphel had not realized the difference until she thought of it like this: each one would have been eligible to be a Named-rank adventurer, a hero of the modern world, if they were alive.

Ovela was shaking with the cheering. Even Lord Fallien and Lady Piral had gone silent when they saw Ouren die—but afterwards, they had cheered the bloody Arteis.

To them, it surely seemed like she was the ghost of salvation. Baron Digneral’s forces were falling back, and his dead littered the field. But Arteis?

“Come, Dame Arteis! Let’s plan an attack! Don’t stop now! This is our chance to push him off Noelictus’ lands!”

She raised a hand as she floated up to the walls. Piral was gesturing eagerly at Digneral’s back. It was Arteis who snapped.

“Lady Piral Ovela, fall silent! It is not you who gave the order, nor you who compelled our attack!”

Piral fell silent, looking outraged a second—then Lord Fallien hesitated.

“If it was Lord Culin or Lady Sasi, we bow to Afiele’s aid, Paladin Arteis.”

“The children had naught to do with it.”

She tossed her head, and now Seraphel felt a lurch in her stomach. Arteis removed her helmet, and her eyes were calm. A crusader’s merciless stare. She spoke crisply.

“Lord Culin and Lady Sasi are children. I would not give them a [General]’s mantle to wear. No. It was I who elected we do battle. Tombwarden, you object?”

“I do, Paladin Arteis. To your cutting down of surrendering [Knights]. It goes against my honor, but you were right—it was now to reveal ourselves. But I cannot in good conscience relish this.”

Dalius floated upwards, less content than Arteis. She bowed to him, but stiffly.

“I hear you, Tombwarden. But the disgraceful conduct of Ovela’s nobility is my concern, as is an invasion into my home!”

“Disgraceful—”

The Twins were outraged, but Arteis landed.

“You waste lives like water even against a powerful foe. I intervene to turn the odds—but you two will fall under *my* command, and Tombwarden

Dalius’! I will accept that or demand Ovela stand down. *This war is now Afiele’s, and I shall drive our foe to the sea.*”

Her eyes were flashing, and Seraphel felt the first twinge—no, she had already felt uneasy. But now she felt afraid.

“Arteis, do you mean to say—”

Duchess Grishen looked alarmed, and Arteis lifted her bloody blade, shaking the last drops of blood off it as she pointed.

“*Yes. To arms, Ovela.* We do not stop here—we will run that Baron down across his lands! We ghosts will split and destroy those hills. We have their location and know how well-defended each Greatbow is. Ser Dalius, I ask you to assume command of the living. *I will lead a vanguard and cut down as many thousands of their soldiers as I can before rejoining you at the river’s delta.*”

“Arteis...”

Dalius was breathing hard. He looked at Fallien and Piral, and both Twins were looking at each other. Arteis swung around to face him.

“Tombwarden—I regret it, but I will make it plain. If you gainsay me in this—the ghosts who follow me shall follow *me*.”

“Come to your senses, Arteis! The Tombwarden is the one who decides where we fight!”

Mustrec shouted, but a good half of the ghosts were floating behind Arteis. Seraphel saw it.

A schism. Dalius slashed his hand.

“I refuse. You named me Tombwarden, Arteis! And we are no army!”

“*Hell has been retaken by evil.* So be it! You were not the first Tombwarden—I regret this, Dalius. Twins, do I have your authority?”

“Yes, Paladin!”

The two chorused, starry-eyed with excitement. The woman looked at Dalius, and he seemed to reach for the sword on his back. The two’s eyes met—and Dalius floated away.

“If you start a war—”

“I will answer to Noelictus’ crown. If His Majesty censures me at the Palace of Twilight, I will accept any punishment. Upon my head, not Afiele’s be it. Thank you, Dalius, for your understanding.”

Arteis bowed to him, and Seraphel saw her turn and fix on Ailendamus like an arrow. And she thought of something just once.

Palace of Twilight? It’s called the Palace of Shadows. Did they rebuild it after...?

Then she saw Arteis draw her blade and rise higher. A terribly frightening woman. Seraphel had been meeting a lot of them.

Cathiel, wild with emotion. Deilfec, with her stare of wrath. Belavierr, the Spider of legends. And now this:

Arteis Ladel, that heroine. Seraphel, even Cara, had only known her tomb and legacy. A woman of great honor, who had bested a Goblin Lord and blazed into Rhir’s hell itself.

But what a terrible, burning passion behind the soul. What wrath fell on Ailendamus—

Even Seraphel felt pain for them. Even she felt afraid.

Digneral

The reports of the disaster at the Ovelian Keep and Ovela’s invasion *into* House Ecte lands and beyond sent shockwaves into Ailendamus’ courts as well as Noelictus’.

Both were not prepared for this, or expected it. Instantly, the Court of Dusk *and* the Court of Masks, as well as Their Majesties, demanded explanations from the Twins of Ovela and Baron of House Ecte respectively.

Indeed, King Nicte Allorev demanded Ovela *cease* its advance and commanded his [General] to apprehend the Twins personally to stop the attack if need be.

—But that was impossible. For it was a ghost who led Ovela screaming over the border, and she was impossible to halt. In fact, her advance was so *fast* that, by the time the courts realized what was happening in both nations, after a single day, she had slaughtered her way over the river and was in House Ecte.

Arteis was burning a path through Ailendamus, and Digneral's own flesh was burnt, his arm in a sling and reeling from battle.

She had spared him—only after he had forced her company of ghosts back after two hours of bloody fighting that had seen them withdraw ‘hurt’.

A hundred ghosts, who could rotate and fly through the ground to avoid spells. High-level ghosts—and only his Drell Knights, Skills, and magic had kept them back. Everyone else?

Baron Digneral had slain one of the ghosts. Just one, by ramming the blade Viscount Visophecine had personally gifted him, a blade of House Shoel's armories, through the ghost's heart.

That had forced Arteis back, though she'd burnt him and broken his arm. *That flame!* She called it the ‘light of Noelictus’. She had walked on hell with it at her back.

It was the color of the fire now burning House Ecte's peaceful lands. Digneral was in hot pursuit, but the Twins were attacking with a number of ghosts at their rear.

Arteis? She was a pure veteran of war. She was...like him, but older. She and five ghosts didn't even bother to fight his forces. They just flew

forwards at a speed even galloping horses couldn't match. And they put Ailendamus to the torch.

It was only then, as he was galloping, that, incredibly, someone found him. A portal in the sky opened—and Duke Rhisveri appeared.

What kind of spell was that? Baron Digneral nearly shouted it was an attack, but the ghosts were not spellcasters by and large. The Duke stood there, his eyes flashing.

“*Digneral!* You incompetent! What is the meaning of this? How did you bungle the entire battle so badly—what are you doing, retreating from the front? Turn and fight or I will have you executed on the spot!”

The Order of Drell looked up as the Duke howled what was an illegal threat even for the [King]'s brother. But Digneral almost agreed. He looked like a coward—but he pointed ahead.

“The ghosts, Duke! *They've routed my forces, and they're ahead! We're in pursuit—*”

“The ghosts? Noelictus' ghosts are *silent*. They have been since the Creler Wars, you dolt! What—”

Then Rhisveri turned and saw the five ghosts flying ahead and looked around.

“...There's smoke everywhere. What—”

Digneral shouted desperately. He had been sending [Messages], but the capital had to be scrambling given how fast Arteis was moving. She was *flying* so fast that she ran into garrisons just getting word of the attack.

“Evacuate everything in front of them! I have abandoned House Ecte to Ovela and ordered everyone into the fortresses—but the ghosts are intent on slaughtering every [Knight] and high-ranking official they can find! They burnt down two forests!”

“They—what? That’s a real ghost. [Greater Appraisal]. A Level 42 [Paladin of Devil’s Bane]? T-that’s not—”

Duke Rhisveri began to grow alarmed. Digneral just stared at Arteis.

Only Level 42? He outlevelled her! But he had never actually met a [Paladin]. They were a class only known as a type of [Knight].

That light, which had burned his troops to ash, was far more powerful than he could have dreamed. Rhisveri’s eyes flicked to Digneral.

“They’re heading to the forest. The Fiter Forest. *Stop them, Digneral.* Are they—what are they doing?”

“They intend to scorch it to rubble. I think she intends to kill everything on her path to the capital. She interrogated two survivors on where the capital *was.*”

Digneral had seen Arteis fly into two smaller groves already and set them on fire. He had called for [Rainfall] spells—but she was burning everything in her path. Rhisveri swore.

“*Ghosts!* How are they alive? Our every intelligence said that the Kingdom of Shade was corrupt and weak—this is bad. We can stop her at the capital. [Message]...Visophecine!”

“*Warn His Majesty! Assemble the Great Knights!*”

Rhisveri swung around. He glanced at Digneral and then back at the forest.

“I’ll tell His Majesty. And get the forces to stop this ghost—but *halt her* before she burns the Fiter Forest! Even if you have to kill yourselves!”

Then he vanished in a thunderclap of sound. Digneral’s estimation of Rhisveri—no, the man was stressed. But why was he so worried about the forest?

It was, to his knowledge, a preserved site for half-Elves, Ailendamus having more than almost any nation in the world. Grown under the aegis of

the attentive [Druids]. He'd even heard they planned on making it a Great Forest someday, with thousand-year-old trees. It seemed like a waste of space to him; it was over a hundred miles wide and stretched from Noelictus' border across the north of Ailendamus.

A monument and pact with the half-Elves, but what about King Itorin II and everything else in that ghost's way? Digneral got his answer five minutes later.

Arteis

"Take cover!"

The five ghosts and Arteis saw the first glowing meteors falling from the sky and dodged. The spells *homed* in on them, but only one ghost got caught. A [Mage] screamed and fell, shrieking, but Arteis popped out of the ground and grabbed them.

"It's true magic! Tier 6 spells at least—"

"Get out of range! Into the forest! So this Kingdom of Glass and Glory has teeth, eh?"

Arteis' own teeth were bared in a smile. She was wounded from fighting Baron Digneral, but she had encountered no foe even close to his strength. The [Knights] were plentiful, but low-level.

That spellcasting, though... it would have wiped out any flying or riding foe, but the ghosts just flew underground—until the underground began to twist around them.

"Someone powerful has a lock on us, Paladin. Do we retreat?"

"If they are at this capital or close by, it would be a telling blow to strike at Ailendamus' heart! Onwards! If nothing else, we burn the forest. Once a blaze begins large enough, not even an [Archmage] will quell it so easily!"

Harry the foe. Part of the reason Arteis had held back from revealing herself and agreed with Ser Dalius was to get a good understanding of Ailendamus

and Baron Digneral. He had slain one of their own.

They *could* die, and the ghosts had to serve Afiele. So. They would never get a chance better than this when their foe was not ready and didn't remember how to face ghosts.

Burn a forest to the ground. Arteis did not relish it, but fire was her domain. She flew into the forest—and therein started a blaze.

Light burned from her sword as she set trees on fire, radiating heat outwards that burned the first, huge trees on the border. A [Mage] threw fire while the others simply used branches to spread the blaze.

“The spells have stopped. Perhaps the caster's wary of the blaze? Feels like rain spells are coming.”

“Then we move up ahead. The [Baron] will move even slower in the trees.”

He was unable to catch her without help. So Arteis kept going faster—faster —

A living torch setting fire to the trees. Then she reached the first half-Elven village and paused.

“You half-Elves. You are no foes of mine, but anyone in Ailendamus is my nemesis. *Flee or burn.* This forest is going up in flames.”

An arrow passed through her face, and she saw a half-Elf lower a bow. Even the half-immortals looked at her with fear. Arteis glanced over her shoulder, but Digneral was miles away. And she wondered if she could burn a path to the capital.

Slaughter a [King] on his throne? If she could—she would. Anything for Afiele, and she did not believe Dalius understood. They were ghosts. They had awoken too late, for great purpose.

This was what they could do, and even Ailendamus, great nation of all, could only look upon them with dismay. Arteis Ladel advanced upon the

half-Elf shooting arrows and forgot, a second, the lesson Digneral had learned:

Both nations had great secrets. And ancient protectors hidden in plain sight.

She had one millisecond to notice the earth *bulging* underfoot before the ground exploded and *punched* her into the sky.

Impossible. Arteis caught herself—and a lance of something sent her crashing down, pinned to the earth as the other ghosts cried. One vanished, and she saw a flash of gold and realized what it was.

Truegold. Ghostbane! And—

“*[Druid]!*”

She howled and saw a woman standing there. Emerging from the woods like she came from the trees. Magistrate Fithea advanced, and the earth quaked for miles as the half-Elves began to flee. Arteis shoved the piece of Truegold off her, feeling agony for the first time in a while.

“That’s powerful earth-magic. *Surround the caster, quickly! Don’t go into the earth!*”

Strange. She had not thought anyone living had that much magic left. This felt almost like a great protector of the trees. Like Dryads and Unicorns and Treants.

But they were all dead. She had seen the last Treants walk into the sea. As for immortals? Dragons had died, and only one evil had settled in Rhir during her time. Lucifen...and their bright counterparts had given her the blades and means to kill the evil. Arteis lifted her blade and burned.

Digneral

His logical world of formations and commonplace reality was shattered. He felt like a time-traveller, a stranger in a foreign land.

He felt like he’d fallen into a storybook.

Ghosts in the air, fire below. That unstoppable [Paladin] who conjured sunlight that had scorched hell itself ages ago.

Ailendamus' despair. *Woe to mortal ambition.* He had truly thought he might sacrifice himself, to buy his nation time for the shame of it.

But here she halted. Arteis Ladel flew backwards, and one of the five ghosts had already vanished, screaming, as golden splinters tore his incorporeal form to shreds. And it was not an army that had done this, but a single woman.

She was a Dwarf, and he knew her as Magistrate Fithea. Her title was Conservator of Forests, and she was a common sight in the palace.

Digneral knew her as a somewhat-fussy old woman who would lecture people on being kind to trees and animals both. She had the King's favor, probably because she was such a valuable link to half-Elves.

But he had never thought of her as a battlemage. Now—she emerged from the forests, and the ghosts scattered before her.

“*[Druid]!*”

She split the earth as she pointed, and vines emerged, grasping for the ghosts who flew away. One of them dove into the ground, but Arteis shouted.

“No, don't—”

Too late. Fithea clapped her hands, and the ground *swirled* around her. She didn't run, or even move, but the earth itself shifted around her. A platform of stone, carrying her across the ground faster than an arrow. She halted over the ghost and spoke.

Her eyes were pale yellow and looked like the wisps of light caught on dew in a forest. Then they shone like the wrath of the land itself.

“*[Greater Transmutation of the Land: Tomb of Khelt].*”

She *clapped* her hands, and the ghosts cried out. One dove—then recoiled as the earth turned golden. Digneral and his band of weary [Soldiers] were frozen in awe.

She turned the entire ground to gold. Not just gold, either. This had a pale wisp of blue about it, and Arteis screamed.

“Truegold! Back, back!”

Bane of ghosts! That was—beyond Tier 5 magic. Who was Fithea?

A spellcaster to rival any Archmage of Wistram! None of the ghosts even went for their comrade. They had been wiped out.

Four ghosts left. Three plus Arteis. They scattered as Arteis shot a burning beam of light at the old Magistrate. The [Mage] was throwing bolts of lightning, and the last ghost had a bow, with which she was launching arrows at the Dwarf. The last of their number shrieked as she fell with a lance in hand, vanishing—another casualty of the shards of ghost-killing metal Fithea was hurling through the air.

Magistrate Fithea turned—and Digneral thought he saw a fierce smile on her lips. She turned—and began to *skate* across the ground.

Like earthbound lightning herself. Stone walls rose, crystal blocking the arrows and magic coming her way. She circled Arteis, and another shard of Truegold nearly struck the [Paladin] from the skies.

However, Arteis deflected the metal shards with her shield and an oath. They seemed to hurt her, but again, she was tougher than the other ghosts.

“Arteis, we have to *flee!*”

The ghost with a bow managed one shout as she took cover. Unable to dodge into the ground, the ghostly [Ranger] climbed—

And a flying [Knight] nearly kicked her out of the skies. The ghost whirled with an oath, and an armored figure with dark skin and a mane of hair like a cape in itself passed *through* her.

“Gilaw! You can’t hurt them without Truegold or magic! Get back!”

Fithea turned, and Digneral breathed. Now he understood. It was one of the Great Knights! By chance or luck, Magistrate Fithea and Great Knight Gilaw, normally assigned to the capital, were touring the forest.

The woman had leapt nearly forty feet *up*! She kicked again, but her foot passed through the recoiling ghost. The [Ranger] shot at her, and the Great Knight leaned out of the way of the arrow. She backed up, frowning, without speaking a word. Then she made an odd screeching sound.

“Regroup!”

Arteis fell back, and Fithea halted, the ground rippling to a halt in front of Digneral. He bowed.

“Magistrate—”

“Ghosts from Noelictus? I warned Rhisveri.”

“Yes, but how did you—”

“Truegold.”

The old woman was ahead of him. In fact, she seemed to be speaking to Great Knight Gilaw, who had come to a halt.

“If you must fight—here. Hold out your hands. Don’t squirm. [Transmute: Truegold].”

Gilaw’s armor changed to that eerie golden color as well! She was changing metal like some [Philosopher-Alchemist] of old! Was she how Ailendamus had such great magics?

If he had not been amazed before, the reappearance of Rhisveri made Digneral realize he was a bit player in a new drama.

“Fithea!”

He screamed back into being, and the old Dwarf looked up.

“I’ve run into your ghosts. They were about to burn a village down, Rhisveri.”

“Nevermind the damn village! Are you alright?”

“They are burning the forests.”

“*Damn the forests! Get out of there!* I’m calling all of House Shoel to arms! Visophecin will be there in minutes—I—I’m on my way.”

“No.”

Magistrate Fithea glanced at Baron Digneral. He wasn’t sure what Rhisveri meant. Even by teleportation, getting here so fast was—

The Duke noticed Digneral at last and recoiled with an oath.

“Digneral, you idiot! What are you doing? Protect Fithea with your life! Throw yourself before the ghosts as a living shield if you must—”

“Rhisveri, be silent. The forest is in danger. *This is my calling.* I feel young enough to stop a few ghosts. The one with flames is dangerous.”

“Too dangerous! Stay right there while I—”

Fithea ignored him. She was watching Arteis; the [Paladin] had moved left while the two other ghosts were using the trees as cover.

“I have Gilaw here. Menorkel too, if need be. We’ll chase them off. Baron, don’t interfere. You’ll get in my way.”

“Yes, Magistrate.”

He was so exhausted he just stood there. Rhisveri cursed—and Arteis pointed a finger down at them.

“*[Dawn Rises in—]*”

Before she could blast the world in burning light, Fithea spoke.

“[Lightning of the Old World].”

It crashed down like a true bolt of lightning. So fast even a ghost didn't have time to dodge it. But the [Paladin] rose, smoking, and the second round began as Great Knight Gilaw leapt at the [Ranger].

She was no artful fighter. Baron Digneral had never seen a Great Knight fight in earnest. A few spars, but he had often wondered what set them apart. Now—he saw it.

She punched the ghost so fast that neither he nor the ghost saw the blow. Two punches, a kick—and the ghost screamed as her essence was torn. She raised a blade—the Great Knight *leapt* ten feet back, then dashed right.

As fast as a Courier. So mighty she punched *through* the ghost a second time. Dying, the ghost wailed.

“*Arteis! Flee!*”

In the skies, the [Paladin] heard her, but she and the last ghost were in danger. Fithea was filling the air with those Truegold shards—but now she clapped her hands.

“One last great spell. Forest, give me strength...[Summoning: Ouroboros, the Snake of Nature].”

A mouth made out of stone. A body made out of mud, water, grass, and even wood—decaying to rot and marsh water and sludge, then blooming again in a thousand flowers, from lilies to creeping vines, before the cycle repeated again.

The snake was a hundred feet long and large enough to swallow Digneral and his mount whole. Even Fithea seemed exhausted, but she didn't have to continue the fight. It *rose*—and the [Mage] vanished, magical barriers and all, with a scream as the Tier 7 magic engulfed him.

Gone in an instant. Then the snake of nature turned on Arteis.

She was outmatched now, the tides reversed. But the [Paladin] who had founded House Ladel simply dropped her shield, lifted her sword two-handed and closed her eyes.

There was more to strength than a number.

“[Armaments: Holy Flame]. Noelictus, Afiele—guide my blade.”

She *dodged* in midair as the snake snapped up at her, and her blade dug into it as it passed. A flaming gouge—as it spun and tracked her again, she whirled and hurled her blade.

It exploded in the summoned beast’s mouth, and Arteis *dove*. She reached up to recreate her blade—

And Gilaw *kicked* her out of the air. The [Paladin] fell, and the Great Knight struck her eight times, tearing her ghostly body to shreds.

Then they landed, and Arteis lifted her fists. She was *slower* than the Great Knight and narrowed her eyes.

“What are you? Some beast of a [Knight]—”

She *leaned* back, knocked a fist aside, and replied with an overhand punch. Gilaw blocked it and threw a flurry of punches with a *cawing* cry. The [Paladin] was unarmed, but she took one punch across her shoulder—caught one punch in the crook of her arm, and struck Gilaw with an uppercut to her jaw. The huge woman staggered, tore free, launched a kick—

Arteis threw an elbow and nearly *snapped* the knee as she struck the flying limb even as it was lashing out. Then she parried two punches—leaned aside—

“Gilaw, back!”

The ground exploded as the Snake of Ouroboros missed. Fithea pointed point-blank, and Arteis produced her sword. She bisected two pieces of Truegold and, panting, backed up.

“Now here comes worthy foes. For shame that you attack my beloved country!”

She was grinning, and Gilaw massaged at her leg slowly. She glanced at Fithea, and the Dwarf woman nodded.

“She’s a blademaster and a martial artist. Don’t go after her or she’ll cut you with that blade. Just keep her back from me. Menorkel is coming. So is Visophecin.”

Gilaw growled, but she eyed Arteis—and nodded. The [Paladin] and Digneral glanced up as he heard a sound.

Thump. Thump.

It sounded like another earthquake. Menorkel? Was that the shy half-Giant boy...

The trees were moving in the distance. Huge redwoods shaking. The earth trembled, and Digneral’s heart beat so hard he felt like whatever he saw next would change him irrevocably.

Alas—or possibly, for the best—it was not to be. Arteis had no more allies, and she took one look at whatever was coming through the trees and nodded.

“There ends my first strike. My comrades, I shall avenge you and all of Ovela. Alone, if need be! *Be warned, Ailendamus.* This is not over.”

She turned and fled. Fithea began shooting spells after her, rains of glowing arrows, but the ghost just flew back the way she came. When comets began falling from the sky again—she cut through them. Screaming in agony—but somehow, Digneral doubted that the long-ranged magic could kill her.

He was on his knees. Shaking. Fithea was speaking to Gilaw and an upset half-Giant, far shorter than the vast presence Digneral had sensed, who flocked around her.

“Children, leave me be. Rhisveri—those were not weak ghosts.”

“I know. We’re going to address it—is that idiotic [Baron] there?”

Fithea glanced at Digneral as he flinched.

“Leave him be. He had no notion those ghosts were there. *You* were the one who wanted to test Noelictus to see if they had guardians. Well, they do. We will discuss it—”

“Good. Come back now. Er—I’ll help clean up this mess. Dead gods. See you soon.”

Then he was gone, and the Baron sat there until the Magistrate walked over.

“You have involved yourself in the heart of Ailendamus’ secrets, Baron. I regret that you faced those ghosts unprepared. That woman...is dangerous beyond the rest.”

“Magistrate, you saved us. But I regret—what use was I? Why did you not lead the charge across to Noelictus—nay, to any land you pleased?”

With her magic and might, they could have overrun any foes! But the old woman just smiled, and he realized she was exhausted as she leaned on her huge protector.

“Ah, but it is you shorter-lived champions, Digneral, who carry Ailendamus. Even Rhisveri knows this, you see. You have the potential to rise higher than me. Come—let us mend what we can. Those ghosts complicate your war. But Truegold *is* their end.”

He knelt there a while and only stood when the Great Knight urged him up with a glare. Then Digneral recollected himself and understood—

He had great secrets on his side, too. And he began to formulate a far, far more ambitious plan. After this defeat—and it was a defeat—

He would need to work twice as hard to deliver both a counter to the ghosts *and* enough to win the Duke’s respect. Then, perhaps he’d know more about the great plan.

But first—he stared after that ghost and shuddered. A burning line drawn across Ailendamus.

That—was [Paladin] Arteis.

Seraphel

Her life changed after that, for a third time. But where she had found Menorome a strange diversion and Ovela a dull conclusion in pain and sudden relief—

This final act was worse than both. For it spanned both locations, and the problems that she had left in Menorome came home.

Returning to the City of Repose was a chaotic affair. Elena—Cara being alive was one thing, and her newfound status in the Synphasia was a great relief.

But all anyone could talk about, including her husband, Fallien, and his sister, was the ghosts and the way they had pushed Ailendamus in a single night.

Nevermind that six ghosts had perished—they had sent thousands of Ailendamus' [Soldiers] to their deaths, and the border with Ovela was so silent that both Twins had decided they could attend the Landsreight.

However, Menorome was *not* at ease. Or rather, the Court of Dusk was not at peace.

Seraphel had been terrified of going to the palace, especially when she heard Queen Cathiel herself would be in rare attendance at the court from the start.

Yet the time had come for the ghosts to meet the crown—and it was a meeting long delayed. It seemed both ghosts *and* crown were aware their meeting would unsettle the other, and until now, both had been trying to set the other at ease.

Now, the backdrop of their meeting was Ovela's foray into Ailendamus, and even Arteis had been ashamed.

Ashamed...and Seraphel had seen Ser Dalius and the ghosts who had chosen not to war remonstrate the others for the casualties amongst their numbers and the disloyalty to the crown. She had not had time to speak with him long, nor had Fallien looked at her twice.

All eyes were on the ghosts, and Arteis looked ready to repent. That was—until she caught sight of the palace and city and choked.

“What has happened to Menorome? My city—this is not the glorious Twilight Palace! What—what is this darkened monstrosity?”

The other ghosts cried out as well, looking dismayed, and Seraphel's heart sank as even Dalius recoiled.

“Is this not the place you knew?”

“Not at all! I thought it was overly dark from afar, but every shadow has a light. This—this is *just* night! Where is the dawn that shines from Menorome's heart? The Kingdom of Shade split with light *and* dark?”

They didn't know this palace. And when Liletrec bowed to them, Arteis recoiled from the shadowy servant and looked around. Her eyes found Seraphel for reassurance.

“Your Highness Seraphel! This—this *is* the palace of Noelictus' crown. The King of Shade?”

“King Nicte Alloreiv is a good man. Just—interesting. You may wish to brace yourself. The Court of Dusk—may not be what you expect, Paladin Arteis.”

Seraphel exchanged a worried look with Dalimont, but Arteis just collected herself and bowed, smooth-faced.

“Of course. Each monarch has their own will and deed. Lead on...Keeper. I apologize for my outburst.”

“Yes. And Cara’s here?”

They had been summoned to the palace first. Seraphel didn’t know, but to her surprise, the [Singer] was back in court.

How Queen Cathiel had not torn her apart was not for Seraphel to know, but then she saw it. Like a perfect picture, it all came crashing down.

Ser Dalius walked across the court as ghosts mingled with the nobles amid a violinist’s song, and Cara met him as if in a trance. They took each other’s hands—and Seraphel couldn’t watch for the tears in her eyes.

Oh, of course. That was how it was. She turned away—and then saw Arteis looking around in dismay.

The [Paladin] stared at the hooded figures, up at the spiders, and then her look of pure incredulity turned to disgust. Then worse—a darkening realization. She put her hand on her sword in distrust—and the ghosts tensed as the hooded figures against the back of the room stirred.

“Lower your swords! These are...the honored ghosts of Afiele. You may approach the throne.”

King Nicte Alloreve smiled, but he was clearly ill-at-ease. Cathiel just stared, and Kadane looked unsure if she should be excited or scared. Seratoito? Sick and ill, and he stared at the two hundred ghosts.

But it was the ghosts who stared back at that odd family. Kadane’s mandibles. Cathiel began to *rant*—and it was Mustrec who whispered.

“This—is nothing like the Court of Dusk I remember.”

“You as well, Mustrec? Arteis—what do you see?”

The [Paladin] was shaking, and she whispered among the ghosts. Seraphel heard, and her heart skipped a beat.

“Those figures on the wall. Those are not mortal men.”

“Enchanted servants? Familiars? Golems?”

The [Paladin] hissed.

“No. Far worse. Those are the Spider’s minions. This court is insanity! This is not the Noelictus I knew—”

But she did advance, and stared up at Cathiel. Arteis bowed low to the ground, knelt before them along with Dalius and the rest. But when she looked up, Seraphel saw it.

Oh, like a [Knight] at ease. It came together: war on the Twin’s smiling faces, the Landsreight’s unease. The royal family’s dysfunction, Guildmistress Deilfec and her corrupted guild—the silent bodyguards, the touch of Belavierr the Spider—all of this was bad enough.

But she saw it in Arteis’ eyes as she stared up at her beloved throne. Treachery. Treachery in the Kingdom of Shade. Dalius raised his eyes, and Seraphel hoped he saw it too. But he just turned—and drew his blade and shouted.

“Who’s there?”

—No one. Just a court ashambles and war and worse, as the mortals recoiled in fear and the Royal Guard drew their blades. The ghosts looked on the living and judged them, and the whispers only grew.

It came to a head at the Winter’s Solstice. But that tragedy—no one could have foreseen. Seraphel’s heart beat and beat. And she heard it, like Cara’s desperate voice.

A song, fluttering fast. Chaos filling the air.

This balance—was a precious board and somewhere there was a falling stone, ready to upset everything. And when it was done, Seraphel had no constant she was sure would last.

End of Ghostsong.

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P I R A T E A B A

the WANDERING INN



BOOK 3

FLOWERS
OF ESTHELM

The Wandering Inn

Volume 3

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I don't dream of seeing. But I do dream of adventures. I think every boy does, and I never forgot that dream even when I grew older.

Yet it's one thing to imagine being transported into another dimension or to another world, and quite another thing if it actually happens. Upon reflection, I think I would have rather eaten my quiche instead before I left, but we can't have everything.

Day 1

When I found myself in another world, I picked up on it right away for a number of reasons. First: I'm pretty darn sure that a food court doesn't have grass inside of it, or trees. Second, it just felt different.

The air smelled strange to me immediately. You think I would have noticed the sun on my skin, but it was the stark difference in the way the wind smelled to me that stood out first. It's like...honestly, it's like the difference between living in a polluted city like New York – no, scratch that, somewhere *really* polluted like Hong Kong or Beijing – for a few months and then going somewhere where the air is pure and clean.

There is a quality to the air. In bad places like airports, it smells sterilized and stale, and that goes double for airplanes. In a polluted place, it's more pervasive than anything else; after a while you get used to it, but then the fog is in your lungs, making even breathing harder than it should be.

The difference between clean air and polluted air is tangible even to people who don't take that much notice of it. But the difference between the relatively clean food court and the place I was now in?

Unimaginable.

I look around, the bacon quiche still in one hand, my walking stick in the other. I feel like I should be freaking out but honestly, I don't want to start running about. I can't tell what's around me right now except that I'm now standing on the grass, and I'd hate to run into a tree, if there are any in the area.

If you haven't guessed by now, I'm blind. That's not legally blind, of which there are many variations. I mean I see nothing. Not blackness, not a distinction between light and dark—nothing. That's fine by me, but most people I've met make a big deal about it.

Normally, I get on just fine no matter where I go. I have good friends, my parents are overprotective, and I can always ask for directions or help in a pinch.

Which would be now. The only problem is, I'm getting the distinct impression I'm alone. My best friend Zoe is *not* sitting at a table a few feet ahead of me, and I can hear birds.

I sweep the ground cautiously around me with my cane, pausing as I feel dirt at the tip and grass. That's definitely not ceramic tiles. Either someone's playing an amazing prank on me or—

“Hello? Zoe? Is anyone there?”

No response. This is like a bad dream, the kind I used to have as a kid where I'm lost in a huge building with no cane and no one around me. Only then I kept imagining something was sneaking up on me and it was dark.

“Hello?”

This...place is clearly somewhere in the light. I can feel sunshine on my skin, and I'm pretty sure it's early morning judging by the dew on the grass. I know that because I've sat down.

Some people freak out when the unexpected happens. If I were someone else I might run around screaming, or panic. But being blind means that you learn bumping into things at high speeds is a bad idea. Plus, I still have the quiche in my hand.

I rest it on my lap as I sit to think. Well, I'm somewhere else. Not in the mall. I might have suspected a prank, but Zoe isn't nearly that cruel, and it's not as if I've blacked out or been distracted. I literally just took a step and found myself...

Here.

“Is it a forest? Or a meadow? A hiking trail?”

I touch gingerly at the grass and ground. Yep. That feels like morning dew. The grass is long and uncut—another sign? I'm not on someone's lawn here. And then I find a flower.

It feels soft under my fingertips. The petals nearly stick to my skin, and I recoil when I realize the head of the flower is *wet*. What kind of flower is this? Has a bird or something pooped on it?

“...No. Nectar.”

It smells sweet and odd, and like *nothing* I’ve ever smelled in my world. Already I’m at the other world conclusion, but this time I’m pretty damn sure.

The flower smells spicy-sweet, but also *dark* if that makes sense. It smells dark like I imagine the shade appears to people—not that I’ve ever seen it for myself. But I can imagine the shade—a wet, creeping thing as wide as an ocean that sucks up sunlight. That’s closest to the smell of this flower.

It’s like nothing I’ve ever smelled before, and I have a good memory. I’ve visited huge greenhouses and even flower gardens across different countries in the world – the Keukenhof Gardens in the Netherlands were my favorite – and never come across this unique smell.

Cautiously, I reach down and pick the flower. I feel a bit bad, but I have to touch it, feel it. I’m aware it could be poisonous, but I don’t care. I smell it again, and this time realize the center of the flower was indeed sticky with that nectar.

Do I dare taste it? No, that’s probably too risky. But that adds to my theory. I am somewhere else, and something...strange has happened to me.

“Magic? Teleportation? Some kind of ultra-vivid hallucination?”

It can’t be real. But some part of me whispers ‘yes it is’. Yes it is.

This is real. You’re in another world.

And that makes me smile. Even if the curtain falls down in the next second or it turns out I’m being tricked. For a second I believe.

The air smells different. Cleaner. Sweeter, even. For that matter, even the sunlight feels...odd. I could have sworn it was quite warm in San Francisco—warm enough that Zoe and I went into a mall to cool down. But today feels like a crisp autumn day.

A breeze ruffles my hair. I smell grass and that strange otherworldly smell of flowers I’ve never seen before. And I hear a bird warbling off in the distance. That at least sounds normal.

It’s such a pleasant day. I could get up and walk into uncertainty, but right here the grass is soft. It could be I’m sitting right at the edge of a cliff and I’d never know. But here is nice.

How long did I sit there, holding the quiche in my lap, just listening to the wind and birds? An hour, maybe. I sat and listened and grew more and more convinced that I was somewhere else. Somewhere special.

That's when I heard the voice. It was distant at first, and then grew louder, accompanied to the sound of branches crackling. *Something* wails and I hear a *thud* off somewhere behind me and to the left.

I get a bit worried. Okay, stepping into another world is a jarring experience, but I was keeping calm by rationalizing it as a Platform 9 and $\frac{3}{4}$'s experience. But no one wants to meet a monster.

Or a bear. Forest + large thing = bear in my mind. But this bear has a voice. And it's upset.

Behind me, I hear the thing stop, and then hear what sounds like sobbing. That's reassuring for me, but then I practically feel something punch something else. It sounds like a tree from all the branches rustling from the impact.

Is it a person? I listen hard. Contrary to public belief, being blind does *not* confer supernatural senses to me. I just use what I have more efficiently. I can sort out the sounds—yes, someone's crying. They've got a deep voice which is why it sounded so odd. And they're hiccupping.

I already feel a bit sympathetic for this person caught in their grief, although the *thumping* aspect I don't like. If they're hitting that tree, then I'm listening to it *splinter* from the impacts.

But there's no helping it. I stand up and raise my voice.

"Hello? Is anyone there? Are you okay?"

Immediately the crying stops. I hear what sounds like the intake of breath. I call out again, turning towards where I heard the person.

"I think I'm lost. I'm sorry, but could I ask you for some help?"

"Help? I'm coming!"

It is a person! I never thought that would be the highlight of my day. But not only is it a person, it's apparently a female person. At least, that's what she sounds like. But she has a very deep voice; not that I object to that. Her voice sounds soothing.

Immediately after she speaks, the mysterious person runs over to me. I hear her crashing through branches as she makes a beeline in my direction.

"I'm here! What's the prob—oh!"

Her footsteps make the ground tremble just a bit as she walks closer. I hold my ground and sense her as best I can.

Heavy. She's definitely that. And big; that's my general impression. And she smells. Not bad per se; but she smells...not exactly normal, I guess

is the best way I could describe it. She's certainly perspiring a bit, but that's not unpleasant.

And then she speaks again, and I hear the worry in her tone. Her voice is deep but smooth, and she has good diction; it's rare to hear someone enunciate as well as she does.

"I'm here. Are you lost, stranger? Are your eyes hurt? You have them closed."

"What? No. I'm—"

I lift my cane a bit and I can *feel* her recoil backwards. I hear her take a step back. Did she think I was going to hit her? I lower the cane and raise a hand.

"I'm sorry. I'm blind. This is my walking cane."

"You can't see?"

The voice sounds shocked. She didn't recognize my cane, either. It's pretty universal—am I *really* in another world?

"Not at all. I can't see you, but I can hear you."

An intake of breath. I feel like whoever's standing in front of me is huge; or at least their lungs are.

"You can't see my face?"

"No. Is something wrong?"

Silence. And then—

"No. Nothing's wrong."

I smile. I'm not sure if I'm smiling at her, but it helps. It always does.

"That's good. I heard you and didn't want to interrupt, but I am in a bit of trouble. My name is Laken Godart."

I offer my hand, and I sense hesitation. But then a hand engulfs mine.

A big hand. But it gives my hand such a delicate squeeze that I barely feel a thing.

"My name is Durene. How did you end up here, Mister Laken?"

Mr. Laken? How odd. Is there any country I know of that uses that kind of title? I smile ruefully.

"I'm not quite sure how I got here. I was at a mall, and I must have turned the wrong corner? Something happened because I was suddenly walking around here."

"Mall? I've never heard of that town. I'm sorry."

My eyebrows shoot up. Either she's a brilliant actor and this is the greatest simulation of all time, or she's serious.

“Can you tell me where I am?”

I think she nods. I’ve been told people do that a lot although I only understood the gesture after someone showed me exactly what they were doing with their head.

“You’re near the village of Riverfarm. In the forest, actually.”

Riverfarm? At least I was right about the forest bit.

“Is that near a city? I was in San Francisco just now and I have no idea how I got here.”

Another pause.

“I’m sorry, but I don’t know where that is. Is it a big city?”

“Very big. What’s the biggest city near here?”

“That would be Bells. It’s over thirty miles away, though.”

“...Is that anywhere in America?”

“America?”

...

This is probably just a dream. Or a mental breakdown, although the psychiatrist my mom hired gave me a clean bill of health for the last few years. This is any number of things, but what I really want, a tiny bit, is for this to be real.

“Sorry Durene, I’m going to go out on a limb here, but...could you tell me what the year is? And what nation I’m in?”

“Nation? Year? I—don’t keep track of the years. I think we’re around 22 A.F.? And, um, we’re not in a nation. No one rules Riverfarm but the village head.”

“Oh my god. I *am* in another world.”

“What?”

“I must be. Durene, do I look...unusual to you?”

A pause. I can feel her drawing slowly closer. I can’t tell, but I think she’s looking me over.

“Well...you dress a bit oddly. You have unusual clothing. There’s a strange symbol of a triangle on your shirt. It looks...colorful.”

I smile, a tiny bit. Being blind means my fashion sense is a bit skewed. I know I’m wearing shorts and a t-shirt, apparently with a logo of the Illuminati eye on it. Zoe told me it looked good, but I have reason to doubt her fashion sense.

“Have you ever seen anything like it before?”

“Not so vividly. Are you a noble? A merchant who sells fabric?”

“No. I’m just blind. And I think—yeah, I think I’m very far from home.”

“Oh. I’m so sorry.”

I shrug.

“It’s not your fault. I think. If it is, I’d love an explanation?”

“What? No! I’d never—”

She’s so easily distressed. That makes me feel a bit guilty.

“I’m sorry. It was a joke.”

“Oh.”

What to say? I’m usually a decent conversationalist. Or at least, I can always find something to talk about even if it’s not well received.

“I heard you crying. Are *you* alright?”

“Me?”

I’ve heard of a blush as well. Based on people’s descriptions and the one time I touched someone while they were blushing, I imagine heat filling their face. That’s certainly how it feels to me, and I suspect, Durene at the moment.

“It—it was nothing. I was just upset, that’s all. I didn’t think anyone was around.”

Her voice is rough with emotion. I pause, but why not follow this? There’s nothing to be gained from holding back. I learned that a long time ago.

“It’s fine if you don’t want to speak about it. But if you want to talk—”

“No.”

I nod. But I can feel her hesitating. So I wait.

“Someone called me a name. That’s all.”

“Ah.”

So many years, so much feeling can go into a single word. I face in her general direction, and I know she’s looking at me. And then I hear something funny.

Rumbling. Gurgling. A massive stomach. And I remember I do have something in one of my hands. I smile even as I sense Durene shifting and presumably, blushing.

“Durene, would you like to share this quiche with me?”

“Are you sure?”

“Why not? Let’s sit and talk. You seem like a nice person.”

I sit down on the ground. After a second, I sense someone sitting next to me. I don't have a fork, but it's no trouble to lever the quiche out of the tin container and break it apart. I give the bigger section to Durene over her protests and we eat and sit and talk.

That was how I met Durene, and my introduction to another world. As I said, I would have liked to eat my quiche first. It was only lukewarm at that point, but at least the company was nice.

Day 2

When I woke up, I once again confirmed that I was in another world. I didn't freak out.

That mildly surprised Durene, when she found I was up and quietly exploring her house. She lives in a rather large house next to a stream. I can't imagine it as a whole yet, but my exploration and her descriptions of the building give me the sense of a building of wood and rough stone, but carefully patched to avoid the elements or nature getting in. The stone floor is only slightly rough on my bare feet, and the lone window has no glass.

In short, this is a medieval building, and from what Durene told me in our hours-long chat yesterday, this is a medieval world. With magic. And only a limited grasp of technology. She was amazed to see my fiberglass cane; she exclaimed over the material as if it were alien to her world, which it was, in a sense.

Now I sit at a table, feeling like a midget in the chair Durene put me in while she clatters around the kitchen. I can smell something cooking, and it sounds like she's making eggs. The scent of warm bread is already filling my nostrils.

"Here you are, Mister Laken. I'm sorry it's a bit burnt."

"It smells delicious. And call me Laken."

I hear and feel the big plate being placed in front of me. After cautious exploration with a fork I find the eggs—only slightly runny—and the toasted bread. Yes, it's crunchy, but it is quite good, and I tell her so.

"Thank you for letting me sleep here. I think I took your only bed. I'm sorry about that."

"Oh, no! It's nothing. And I like sleeping outside."

"Pretty liar."

Well. I think that's the first time I've ever startled someone into silence so quickly. I hear her shifting, clearing her throat, and then she bursts out.

"Aren't you worried?"

I raise my eyebrow. I have no idea if it looks good, but friends assured me it did, and I fell in love with the idea after reading a story where the main character did it to great effect.

"About what?"

"Well, you said you're lost. Alone. In another...another world? How are you so calm?"

That makes me smile. I may act calm, but I spent a good bit of last night while Durene was snoring outside freaking out and trying to affirm I really wasn't hallucinating. I have a sore arm from all the times I've pinched myself.

"What's the point of freaking out? I'm more excited than anything else, actually. I'm in another world, one with magic. There's no magic where I come from."

"But you told me you have so many strange things. Like these 'cars' and 'malls'. It sounds amazing."

"I'm surprised you believe me, to be honest. If I heard someone talking about my world, I'd assume they were crazy."

"But you make it sound *real*. And that stick you have which folds up—"

Another miraculous invention by her standards. I think it was actually that which convinced Durene I was from another world. That, and my iPhone. I think Siri scared Durene more than anything else.

Yes, it turns out I have no wireless, and without battery I turned Siri off to save energy. But having an iPhone, even one with limited power, is amazingly useful in a survival situation, which is what I find myself in.

So is having a friend. I smile at Durene.

"I don't think my world is that special. But I *am* glad you found me, Durene. I've always found that I can trust most strangers."

Another pause. Another hypothetical blush.

"Really? But you can't even see—and you just trusted me to help you. I could be—"

She pauses.

"Someone bad."

"But you're not. And I have a good sense for people, or at least, I like to think so. You seem like a very nice person, Durene."

“I—thank you. But you can’t see—”

I smile wryly.

“I do notice some things. For instance, I know you’re taller than me. And stronger. And you have calluses on your hand, your table is cracked here—and you have a big appetite.”

It’s hard not to notice her chomping down her food, to be honest. Durene shifts in her chair, making the wood creak.

“I’m sorry.”

“What? What are you sorry for?”

“Um—”

“I quite enjoyed the eggs and toast. Did you make it yourself?”

This time I think she nods, because there’s a bit of silence before she speaks.

“Oh! Yes! I eat a lot. So I have a big garden and I um, raise chickens and pigs and other animals. But I can’t cook well because I don’t have any skills.”

“That seems rather harsh. Your food tasted good to me.”

Silence. And then—

“Thank you. But I have to buy a lot of food anyways. The villagers sell me lots of things I can’t make by myself.”

“So you live in a village? How many people live there?”

If it seems odd we didn’t cover that yesterday, well, there’s a lot of explanations and confirming to be done when you think you’ve ended up in another world. Another part is convincing a scared young woman that you haven’t trapped a person in your iPhone.

Is she young? Durene sounds like she’s a bit younger than I am. Of course, I’m terrible at judging ages so she could be anywhere from my age to still in her teens. Girls grow up quicker than guys, after all.

Back to the conversation. Durene apparently lives in a small village of around sixty souls, most of whom live closer to each other. They inhabit a lovely area of farming land fed by a river, hence the name Riverfarm. The people there grow crops and raise animals—they have a blacksmith, and a dedicated person to go and trade for them at a town, that person having the most skill at buying and selling.

The people in this village live together in large families. The children often go out to learn jobs in other towns as they grow, or manage the family

business. It's rare to see a single new face in a month, let alone a group of people aside from adventurers or Runners now and then.

Oh yes, this world has adventurers and the weirdest postal service I can imagine. But what stands out to me in all of Durene's explanations is an odd...lack of detail. Namely herself.

Durene doesn't live in the village. From what she says, the only other people who live alone are bachelors or bachelorettes or those who have lost their partners. But Durene is far too young to fit either criteria, and she tells me she's never met an adventurer, despite them being popular with all the kids.

I smell a rat. And Durene. She still smells...off. If I met other people I might understand what's different about her, but until then I just keep the conversation going and tell her a bit about where I come from.

That's me Laken Godart, blind son to two fairly affluent parents, one a lawyer, the other a businessman. I've travelled more places than Durene's heard of, and I'm blind. That's a basic description, but the key to selling yourself is embellishment.

And all too soon, I find that Durene's big breakfast has affected me in another way. I clear my throat politely.

"Uh, Durene? Can you help me get to the bathroom again?"

Yes, it's embarrassing to have to ask someone you've just met to help you out, but I'm used to it. Don't want to walk into the ladies' room now, do I? But then, they've always been quite considerate the two times I've done it by accident.

Anyways, it's always easier if I ask for help, especially since any door could be the wrong one. And Durene is happy to help.

"No problem. This way—oops! Let me just push this aside—the door's over here."

She's very considerate. Normally people have a hard time directing me, but she's gotten the hang of it quite quickly. She lets me grab onto her arm—I can feel her muscles rippling every time she shifts—and she walks forwards at a reasonably fast pace.

It's not as if I have trouble moving around, and I can sense whether she's walking up an incline or stepping around something. It's natural to me, and once I explained that to Durene she got the trick of it quickly.

Her bathroom is an outhouse located outside of her home and a ways away from the stream. She has to wait at a respectful distance afterwards,

but I don't take long. There's only one problem.

"Do you have any toilet paper? Uh, anything to wipe with?"

"I'll get some leaves!"

"Leaves? Hello? Durene?"

It turns out toilet paper is a luxury so rare Durene's never heard of it before. But the leaves she gives me are serviceable, and my butt doesn't complain too much.

The outhouse is definitely an outhouse in the sense that I know there's no water below me as I toss the leaves down. But it smells nice; Durene's put some fragrant herb there to chase away the smells. I say as much as I leave.

"Your home seems very nice, Durene. I'm envious."

"It's nothing special. It's really not. It's—crude."

"I don't think so. But uh, do you have anywhere I can wash up? And some soap?"

"Soap?"

It takes me a while to get across the basic idea of hygiene to Durene. That's my first worry. But she boils some hot water for me and when I'm reassured it's not scalding, I use that.

"You really need to wash your hands, Durene. In my world, countless people died in the past because they didn't keep themselves clean enough."

"Really?"

It's amazing, flattering, and humbling how Durene takes all my statements at face-value. I tell her about the Black Plague, and within minutes she's swearing up and down to buy some soap the next time someone goes into town.

Before I know it, it's lunch-time. I could certainly use something to eat, and Durene takes me around the garden, letting me feel the growing plants and the bunch of potatoes she yanks up.

But then we hit a problem. Durene goes into the kitchen to cook them while I sit outside and listen. But after twenty minutes I know something's wrong. I can hear her trying to be quiet, but the clattering and the burnt smell can't be so easily hidden.

"Is everything okay? Durene?"

"I—I'm sorry."

There's a catch in her voice when she comes out and tells me she's ruined the potatoes. I don't get it, but if there was a fire alarm in her house

it would be blaring. She doesn't even let me inspect the ruined food; apparently it's so burned she just dumped it outside for the pigs.

"I can't cook potatoes. I'm sorry. I normally eat them raw."

"Well, we can't have that. Let me help you."

"Help? But you—"

"I can't see, but I *can* cook. Come on!"

I reach out and touch her arm. It's a big arm, and she recoils instantly. But I soothe her and guide her back to the kitchen.

It's an odd thing, cooking while mainly instructing someone else. Odd, but fun. Only for me at first, but then Durene gets into it.

We make sautéed potatoes. It's an easy recipe, but I have to show Durene how to cut properly at first. I hear her cut herself twice before I realize her form is off.

"Like this, see? If you're cutting leaves like this rosemary—do it like this."

Durene gasps, but I place the knife at my knuckles and roll it across the cutting board, slowly slicing the herbs into small slices.

"Easy as anything. Don't worry; even if you can't see, there's no way to cut yourself like this, see?"

"I do! That's incredible!"

"It's not. Really. Now, let's get to work on the rest of those potatoes, okay?"

"Okay. The chopped potatoes are...here. We boil them?"

"That's right. Is the water boiling? And you added the salt? Put them in. They'll go there for about four minutes, okay? Now. Where's the pan?"

"I put the oil in."

"Now the potatoes. Flat side down. There. Doesn't that sound good?"

The sizzling oil makes my stomach wake up. I smile as I hear Durene clumsily sliding the sliced potatoes around the pan.

"Is it crispy golden brown? Okay, let's reduce the heat. Now...a bit of butter. Just a bit...and the rosemary...doesn't that smell delicious?"

"It does! It does!"

Success. We sit down and Durene eats her food as if it's the best food she's ever had. Apparently, it is.

"I've never cooked anything like that before. Do you have a Skill? You must!"

"I wouldn't call it skill. I just learned from a great chef."

Thank you Gordon Ramsay. I might not be able to see them cook, but I do love chefs who tell me exactly what they're doing.

"Are you a [Chef]? Is that your class?"

That's an odd way of putting things. I shrug, a bit embarrassed.

"I wanted to be a professional chef, and then a professional food critic when I was younger. I gave up on that when I found out someone else had already become blind Masterchef. And, it has to be said, I'm not that good at cooking."

"But this—"

"It's not nearly as good as something professional chefs can make, believe me. And you did all the hard work."

"You know so much, though."

I want to squirm a bit with embarrassment.

"I just studied a lot of different professions, that's all. Chef, food critic...at one point I wanted to be a billiards player, but that's not actually possible. I wanted to do anything that wasn't boring, so I tried a lot of things."

"That's so amazing. So much better than I am."

I think she's staring at me. I can feel her proximity towards me. Her voice is also much more intent—she sounds fascinated. I can't help but smile.

"You'd be surprised what you can pick up if you work at it. Forget cooking—I once disassembled and reassembled an old computer by hand. That's...like a complicated device."

"I wouldn't know. I...I only have the [Farmer] class."

There it is again. Class? I frown.

"Classes? Do you mean jobs? You mean, you get assigned a job?"

"No. I'm just a [Farmer]. Level 6. Do you not have classes in your world?"

"Oh wow."

Is it obvious? Did I not notice it because I can't see? But Durene assures me she doesn't have her class and level floating above her head like an MMORPG. Even so, my mind is blown because now I realize I'm in a video game. Or something like a video game.

"You mean, you played games with the fates of people?"

"No! It was all just pretend. But it's exactly like how you're describing your world."

“Oh.”

We sit together, in her garden, talking. By this point Durene and I are comfortable enough to sit closer than before, and yes, she is tall. I’m not short myself; apparently I’m around 184 cm, or around 6’1” for people using the horrible US measuring system, but Durene is at least a head higher than I am. Possibly bigger; she hunches over as we talk.

And she is huge. And conscious of that; she treats me even more like a glass object than people who just know I’m blind. I am grateful in her case, though; it does feel a bit like a giant is keeping me company.

Hmm. A giant?

One last detail: Durene’s skin is rougher than normal. Her inside palm is fairly smooth, if callused, but the few times I brushed against the outside of her skin, it was surprisingly rough and even felt cracked in places.

Odd. But she is a great listener, and we sit together long into the night. I tell her stories, and she tells me of this world. Magic and adventurers and a gaming system.

Dinner that night is marinated mushrooms, again thanks to me marathon watching Ramsay videos. It’s good that I remember so many vegetarian dishes; Durene likes meat, but it is apparently a rare delicacy for her, despite the pigs she introduced me to earlier today.

We don’t have any vinegar, but Durene’s garden is plentiful, and everything is so high quality that we barely need any seasoning to make it go down. Fresh water from the stream completes the meal, and Durene eats four times what I do. Good thing we made a lot.

Sometimes I wish I could see. I have no idea what it would be like, and usually I don’t ever care. But when I’m having a bad day or I’m frustrated and wish things were easier, I wish I could see.

But now, I just want to see her face. Even though it seems like Durene is self-conscious about it.

I wonder why. I wonder as I tuck myself into her bed and listen to her snoring outside.

At least I know she’s not a Troll. The ones from the Hobbit turn into stone in the morning, don’t they? Maybe people just grow really big in this world.

Maybe. But she’s still a good person, regardless.

Day 3

Apparently, one of Durene's obsessions is fish. Understandably so; she can't catch much game and she sells most of her pigs rather than eat them. Her occasional chicken only comes when one dies, and as I've observed, she has trouble cooking even the most basic of meals.

But fish? Fish is hard to get wrong, and Durene has a crude fishing rod that she tries to catch fish at the stream with almost every day. Apparently, she has little success and I figure out why quite soon.

"You need some bait that wriggles. Worms are better. And you're moving the line too much. Let the fish bite before you pull it out of the water. See? Patience is key."

It's amazing. But no one's ever taught Durene this, and she observes me fishing with rapt attention. I feel—

I feel happy to teach her, and supremely annoyed no one ever taught her something as simple as this. Do people in her village not know how to fish?

Or is there another reason why she lives alone?

I get half my answer after I yank the second small fish out of the stream, much to Durene's delight. I hear voices, laughter; the sounds of several children. And then I hear the voices.

"Freak! Come out, Freak!"

Beside me, on the grass, Durene goes still. I pause, the crude clay mug Durene gave me half full as I scoop water out of the stream.

"Where is she? Freak!"

I hear merry laughter, running, shouts of joy at odds with the words and tone in the children's voices. It doesn't take them long to find us.

"Freak! Freaky freak! Fr—who's *that*?"

I turn my head as the sounds of running feet stop. I counted...six kids? All young; probably around ten. Mostly boys, although there's one girl in there. They pause uncertainly.

"This is Laken. He's a stranger to these parts."

Durene tries to explain. I smile and introduce myself, but the instant the children discover I'm blind, respectfulness vanishes.

"He's blind!"

"A freak! Freak's gotta friend!"

"Freaks!"

Is there something in the water here? Or is it just them? I frown at the kids.

“That’s not a word you should be using about Durene.”

“But she’s a *freak*!”

One of the boys protests. Then I hear a yelp and the girl speaks.

“I think he don’t know. He can’t see her!”

“That’s right!”

More exclamations.

“You should run, Mister! Durene’ll eat your heart out!”

“No I won’t!”

“Aah! Run from the freak! She’s gone mad!”

Durene stands up in anguish. And then I hear her yelp. Someone’s tossed a stone at her! I hear it plop into the stream.

“Eat dirt, Freak!”

Okay, mudballs. Another one flies. Durene’s not doing anything to defend herself, so I stand up. The mug of water is still in my hands. For a second I’m tempted to hurl it but—that wouldn’t be right. The children go silent. What should I say?

“It’s nice to meet all of you. Cheers, mates.”

I raise the mug of water in their general direction and then drink from it. Honestly, it tastes a bit like clay. I look at the kids, or rather, in their general direction I hope.

“Now piss off.”

Silence. I keep my face still. I’ve never actually stared anyone in the eye mainly because I could miss, and I can barely keep my eyes open for a staring contest in any case. My eyes still get watery even if I can’t see.

But I am good at holding still and remaining calm. The children aren’t. After a few more seconds I hear them retreat.

I sit back down next to Durene. She’s trembling.

“You okay?”

I keep my tone light as I reach for the fishing pole again. I can’t find it, but then Durene silently presses it into my hands.

“Do you know what I meant when I said ‘cheers’? It’s an expression from another culture. It means, well, it’s something you say before you have a drink, or at a party.”

“Really?”

Her voice is quivery, but it is curious. I nod and smile.

“I met an Australian guy once who could make that word sound like a threat. He said it to a bunch of soldiers who were bothering us and—well,

it's not always polite. It's all about nuance, you see?"

More silence. I hear Durene gulp.

"I—I'm sorry. What they said—"

"—Is none of my concern. Those little wankers were being obnoxious anyways. They're too good to be called brats. Do they harass you often?"

It's nice to know more than one culture. It helps when you want to add to your repertoire of insults. Durene laughs shakily, then goes quiet again.

"Sometimes. I mean, they come by sometimes but they don't do more than throw things."

"Like rocks?"

Silence is my answer. I clear my throat.

"They're miserable little monsters; don't listen to them. Anyways, they're just kids, aren't they? Can't you chase them off?"

"I couldn't do that! I might hurt someone, and then—"

She sounds genuinely shocked. And afraid. Is she worried about the mob of stereotypical farmers with pitchforks? But that had to come from somewhere. Maybe she's right to be passive.

"I'm sorry if I got you in trouble. But I couldn't stand by and let them harass you."

"It's okay. I think. Yes, it's okay. But I'm surprised you weren't angrier when they called you a freak. *You're* not."

Again, her tone suggests...what? Depression? Low self-esteem, certainly. But the clues aren't all there yet, even if I know most of what's going on. As for me...I shrug.

"I used to be a lot angrier than this. But I've gotten calmer now; I don't lose my temper that much. I've been called names too."

"Really?"

I smile again, but this time with an edge.

"Everyone gets called names. I'm just an easier target since I can't see anything coming. Then again, I get it. When you're a kid, anything weird is a target. Anything different or scary...it's easier to shout insults than get to know the person. That doesn't mean I think what those brats did was right, of course. Next time one of them calls you names, hit him. Or just call him names as well."

"I couldn't hit anyone! And I'm not good with insults."

"What? Insults are easy. Come on, try one. Call me something."

"I—I don't know. What would I even call them?"

“Unexploded pimple? Pitiful asshat? Cowardly mushroom? Insults can be anything you want them to be.”

The laugh that comes out of Durene is more like a bark of amusement, but it’s genuine and real.

“Tell you what. Let’s grill up these fish and I can teach you some of the really pithy insults I’ve heard of, okay? You might want to cover your ears though; some of them could make a sailor blush.”

She laughs delightedly and I smile again. It’s a better day, despite the kids. And the fish isn’t even burnt this time.

Day 5

I find myself spending almost all my time with Durene day by day. She’s an open person and easy to talk to; she likes listening more than she likes speaking, but she can break down this strange world into easy-to-understand fragments for me.

She’s in the middle of giving me a history lesson about some version of Alexander the Great when I hear a shout. I’m ready for the kids this time, but to my surprise, only one comes running.

“Durene! The wagon’s lost a wheel! Come and lift it, our Da says!”

“What? The wagon? I’m on my way!”

Durene jumps to her feet with amazing agility, and then hesitates.

“I have to go help, Laken. Will you be okay? I can take you there—”

“I’m fine. Go. I’ll be okay until you come back.”

Again, being blind is not like being porcelain. I let Durene run off with the kid and think of what to do. Twenty minutes later, Durene thunders back to the cottage looking for me.

I’m fishing.

“Durene. You’re back. Is everything okay?”

She smells a bit of hay and some other animal scent. And a bit more of that musky odor that’s probably her sweat. I hear her clear the stream in one jump.

“Everything’s fine. I helped Mister Prost with his wagon; that’s all. The axle of the wheel broke, so he had Finnon go get me.”

“Huh. Do they always call on you for help? It seems like they’d need a team of people to move a busted wagon.”

She shifts next to me. Uncomfortably? It's surprisingly easy to tell when someone's hiding something even if you can't read their face.

"Oh—it wasn't that hard. I just had to help lift it up a bit, that's all."

She doesn't even sound winded. But she ran off and came back in less than ten minutes and helped a farmer put a new wheel on a wagon?

Odd. Odd, odd, odd, odd...

"You do repairs often, then? That's pretty handy of you."

"Well, I don't have a class. But if they need help lifting or, you know, raising a barn—"

"Gotcha. So how bad is the damage?"

"They'll have to fix it later, but it looks like it was just the axle that went. I just got the wagon back to their home so they could give old Evera a rest. She's their plow horse and she gets tired quickly."

Okay, so she *pulled* a wagon which might or might not have been full of produce an unspecified distance. Hmm.

It could just be her class. Durene said she was a Level 6 [Farmer], but she has one [Enhanced Strength] skill already. Apparently that makes her way stronger than normal; when I asked her to demonstrate, she lifted me up with one hand as if I was a feather.

But the skin? And the things those kids said? What could that—

Bah. What am I, a detective? The answer is no, because I can barely solve a Sherlock Holmes mystery, let alone figure out those stupid wire puzzles. And Durene deserves respect from me, if no one else.

She'll tell me when she's ready.

Day 6

"I need a class."

That was what I told Durene when she woke up in the morning. I get up before she does; not that either of us are late sleepers. We're both morning people actually, although I tend to function just as well in the dark as in the light for obvious reasons.

But I do like to hear the birds sing and feel the sunlight on my face. I don't mind relaxing for an hour or two by myself in the mornings. As Zoe once told me, I'm the chilliest blind guy she knows, which is to say I'm the only blind guy she knows. She knows a blind girl—Teresa, but she and I don't get along.

I hate Teresa.

Durene is silent for a long moment after I tell her this. We made doughy crepes this morning and added some wild berries, but she stops eating them now.

“Why?”

“Isn’t it what people do in this world? You told me no one you know didn’t have a class.”

“That’s true. But...”

I wait, yet no further thought comes. I explain myself while I try to see what’s making her upset.

“I’ve put a lot of thought into it, and I need to have a class to survive in this world. I can’t just rely on your goodwill forever.”

“But a class—that means you’d go and get a job, right? You’d...leave.”

Oh. *Oh*. I feel like an idiot.

“I don’t want to be a burden, Durene. I’m already making you sleep outside and now you have to feed two mouths.”

“That’s not a problem!”

The table shifts as Durene moves. She apologizes, and then her tone changes, becomes more pleading.

“I don’t mind the grass! I don’t! And you eat a lot less than I do. I wouldn’t mind you staying! I...like having you around.”

What do I say? What do I do? Whatever it is, it must be something that won’t break her tender heart.

“You know I have a home, Durene, and a family. They’re probably worried sick about me. I want to get back to them.”

I can almost feel her drooping at the other side of the table. I clear my throat and go on.

“*But* I do enjoy staying here with you. If you’re sure I won’t be a burden, I’d love to stay here. I just mentioned a class because it’s fascinating, really.”

“You’ll stay here? You’re sure?”

It’s not pathetic how eager she sounds, how hopeful. It’s heartbreaking. Who left this girl alone? I nod.

“I doubt there’s many jobs for a blind person in your world anyways. Unless I can learn magic? I’d love to learn that.”

“I don’t know. I’ve heard of spellbooks, but I don’t know if mages learn any other way.”

I make a face, mildly outraged as I eat more crepe. Even in this world I'm handicapped by a lack of braille books? And I very much doubt there's any kind of audio spellbook.

"Well, that idea's out. I guess I'll have to sleep on it."

Then I have another idea. I suggest it to Durene as I help her wash the pottery dishes. She doesn't use soap, but hot water works pretty well. She can tolerate the heat far better than I, though. But her hands are clumsier, so we both work slow.

"Why don't you show me around your village?"

Durene nearly drops the cup she's holding. I push it back into the bucket of water just in time; the splash gets water all over my clothes.

"What's wrong? I haven't introduced myself, and I'm sure they're curious about me."

"I—I wouldn't want to bother you."

"It's fine. I like meeting people. Besides, I have to meet them sooner or later, don't I?"

"I guess."

Day 8

It takes me two more days for me to convince Durene to take me into the village. She resists, stonewalls—not so much out of reluctance to visit on her behalf, but for fear of how the villagers will treat me, I think.

And how do the villagers treat me?

With kindness.

Oh, they knew a stranger had moved into Durene's house, but no one had come by. I think they were more apprehensive than curious, and Durene herself might have told them to steer clear before then. It isn't as if we are always together; she made several trips into the village prior to my arrival, and I can only speculate I was the topic of gossip.

When Durene finally lets me into the village, I hear a few mutters, but Prost, the [Farmer] who Durene had helped out a few days ago, is the first to shake my hand.

"You've got a fine grip, son. You'd be a good farmer."

"Ah, but I'd keep trying to milk the bull, and that wouldn't end up well for anyone, would it?"

A joke, a laugh, and I change from the scary unknown to someone approachable, even likeable. One mother smacks her son for calling me names, and soon I'm introducing myself as a traveler from far off, sidetracked by a spell and relying on Durene for help.

That bit of fiction is met by approval from all the villagers, but later on Prost takes me aside as Durene helps lift a few kegs for one of the farmers.

"I wouldn't say much about Durene—she's a good helper in times of need, but she's a bit—"

"She seems like a nice, normal young woman to me. Wouldn't you agree?"

I shut him down in an instant. I don't want to know. Not from him. Not from someone who isn't Durene who's chosen to tell me. That ends the conversation; it's awkward for a few moments until I ask about farming around here. Turns out that these farmers have quite the variety of crops, and they're fascinated when I talk about greenhouses and crop rotation. Some high-level [Farmers] have Skills that approximate those effects, and soon I'm actually giving out vague advice on farming techniques I half-remember. Too bad I can't give them a combine harvester.

Durene hovers around me anxiously at first, but then relaxes as time went by. The other villagers treat her—well, I guess. They have a huge mug of milk for her, and she helps drag a huge tree that had fallen out of the way. But—

We leave the village after several hours, with invitations for me to call on various families for a meal and conversation. I can tell stories about the places I've been to if I omit the parts that they wouldn't understand, and in this small village I'm the equivalent of a celebrity, or a novelty.

The villagers like me. I think I can say that with confidence. They think I'm kind, charming, and okay, mad as a loon. But Farmer Prost's wife Yesel gives me a basket full of goods to take back to Durene's home—or rather, she gives Durene that, and I met a good deal of people that day. All in all it was a success.

I just wonder why they dislike Durene so. Or maybe not dislike? She's clearly known them all her life. But there's a wall between her and them, and no matter how kindly the villagers are towards her and no matter how hard she tries to be as helpful and meek as possible, they still keep their distance from her. I hear it in their tones and observe it through their actions.

It makes me hate them, just a little.

Day 11

I woke up knowing what class I'd have. I was so antsy that over breakfast I nearly put my hand on the frying pan in distraction. I broke the news to Durene as we ate cheese on scrambled eggs; neither of us could do omelettes.

"I think I'll become an [Emperor]. Do you know if I have to declare that? Or is it just doing something that gives you the class?"

Durene choked on her eggs and I had to listen to her splutter for a while before any coherent words came out.

"That's impossible! Laken! What are you saying?"

"I'm going to be an [Emperor]. It seems like the easiest class for me to take, and perhaps I'll gain some useful skills."

Honestly, it was the first class that came into my mind as a viable option. But Durene told me flat out it was impossible. I told her she was wrong.

"You *can* be an [Emperor], Durene. You can, and I can."

"It's not possible! To do that—you'd need a kingdom, and a palace and white horse and—and—"

Her voice trails off, unable to even describe my folly. I can only smile.

"But you *can*, Durene. I know of a man, an ordinary man, who became an Emperor. All by himself, although he was poor and he had no palace or horse."

"Really? Who?"

There's skepticism, but curiosity and eagerness in her voice in equal measure. She always loves stories from my world. This one puts a grin on my face even as I speak.

"He was known as Emperor Norton the 1st of America. He was a real man who became an Emperor just by calling himself one. I always loved his story."

"Emperor? But you said America has no rulers. Only someone with the [President] class."

My explanations of how my world works might have gotten a bit jumbled. I shake my head.

“That’s true. But Norton didn’t care what the rules were. One day, he declared himself Emperor. And he lived and died acting as one.”

It’s an amazing story, and one I have to struggle to do justice to. How can I explain to Durene the tale of Joshua Norton, a failed businessman who one day woke up and sent letters to every newspaper in San Francisco proclaiming himself as the Emperor of the United States?

Well, sort of like that, actually.

“He made proclamations and sent orders to the army—none of which were ever obeyed—and he even made his own money. I know it sounds ridiculous, Durene, and I’ll just bet you’re smiling, but here’s the crazy thing: it worked! The people let him go around calling himself Emperor, and in time they began treating him like one.”

“They didn’t.”

“They did. Not all of course, but he eventually made his own money and became known throughout the city. The people of San Francisco accepted his currency, and he dined in the finest restaurants and went to famous plays in the theater where they would hold a seat for him. When he died, over thirty thousand people went to his funeral.”

Durene listens in silence, rapt with attention. I can only imagine it myself. His story captured my heart.

“Some say he was a madman. And maybe he was; he probably was, honestly. But he also dared to dream. And that’s something I’ve always admired about him.”

He dared to dream. There are worse things to be remembered by. And unlike the rich businessmen and famous stars and politicians of the day, Norton I is still marked in history as the first and only Emperor of the United States. It may seem funny to most people, but I think he’s the one laughing in the end.

“If one man can declare himself Emperor, I don’t see why I can’t follow suit. Kings might be born to rule, but the first kings were just men with an army who made themselves crowns. I might not have an army, or a crown, but it’s worth a shot.”

“Maybe.”

As impressed as she is by the story, I can hear the doubt oozing from Durene’s every word. But I just grin.

“I’m in another world, Durene, and from what you’ve said, classes rule this place. Why not take one of the best ones if I can? So. You can be my

witness.”

I stand up dramatically, praying I don’t hit anything by accident as I gesture grandly.

“Hear my words, that they may be passed down for posterity. On this day, I, Laken Godart, declare myself Emperor of the Unseen, sovereign lord and ruler of all I survey. Not only Emperor; I declare myself Protector of Durene’s House as well.”

For a second I hold the pose, and then hear Durene giggle. It sounds amazing coming from her deep voice. I smile and sit back down.

“You can’t *do* that! What if someone heard you?”

“Well, then I’d demand that they show me the proper respect I deserve. And ask for their taxes. You owe me a tithe, I believe. I demand your finest crepe as your [Emperor].”

Giggling like a girl, Durene passes me one. I eat it with an air of triumph, and tell her several more jokes that make her laugh.

And that’s good. That alone is worth the crazy attempt. But as I sleep that night, I can’t help but think that it would be nice if I could be [Emperor]. I’d make the world a better place, or at least, try to.

I’d like to hear Durene laugh a lot more, and make it so she never has to cry herself to sleep another night.

In my heart, as I let sleep overtake me, I *do* believe I could do it. I believe. That’s what I learned to do. I believe I can be something more than people expect of me.

My eyes close. I breathe out. And then I hear a voice in my mind.

[Emperor Class Obtained!]

[Emperor Level 1!]

[Skill – Aura of the Emperor obtained!]

“Das war ja einfach!”

Day 12

Durene is in a state of panic; I’m calm.

Sort of calm. I’m freaking out, but in a good way. Durene’s just freaking out.

I blink as she tromps past me, nearly hitting my leg. Her voice is strained as she talks out loud.

“It can’t be! You don’t have any fancy clothes! How can you be an—an —[Emperor]? It doesn’t make sense!”

I don’t know. But I do know, at the same time. I sit up straight. I can’t tell how this new Skill I’ve received works, but I feel a bit...different. A bit more secure in myself. I was right. I dreamed, and I was right.

“Durene. Is an [Emperor] simply defined by his clothes? A king is still a king in rags, after all. It may sound silly, but in this world people become what they believe, I think. You haven’t become a [Cook] because you don’t think you can be one. But I? I think I can do anything I want to. And I think you can too.”

She stops mid-step. I can sense her facing me.

“I—I have to go. I have to—go.”

She practically knocks the door down trying to get away. I sit and think in her house, trying to figure out what it means. Something. What can an [Emperor] do? What could my skills do? Is it even practical? How can I get home?

Someday, I want to go home. Even if Durene is here, I...

I need to find my family again.

When the door opens again, Durene comes in silent, but no longer panicking. She avoids the topic of my class and I do too, at least for a bit.

“You have a nice home, Durene. But I’d love to visit a town someday, or a city.”

She hesitates.

“I—I want to, too. But it’s tricky...”

I don’t ask why. Instead I just nod.

“You’ve said there are other continents in this world, filled with all kinds of different species.”

“...Yes.”

“Where are we? What continent are we on?”

“Izril. We’re on Izril.”

“Huh. Sounds almost familiar.”

3.01 E

Day 13

I am an [Emperor]. That is fact.

But I don't know what it means. After an entire day of speculation and worry, Durene has no more answers for me. Myself, I'm just content to find out.

I guess it's because of my class that Durene is freaking out so much. To me, it's just a title that doesn't mean much; something that happened to me because I tried something new. But to Durene, that class automatically makes me royalty.

No— isn't an [Emperor] even higher in status than a [King]? A king might rule by virtue of lineage, but an emperor could in theory rule over multiple countries, and thus kings.

Huh.

Wow.

I guess it's a huge deal, but again, I'm only Level 1, and all I have is one odd skill. When I told Durene, she said she couldn't see anything like an aura about me, but Skills don't work all the time necessarily. Some, like her [Enhanced Strength] skill are essentially permanent passive changes, but others have to be used.

As far as I can tell, there's no word or catchphrase that activates [Aura of the Emperor]. Believe me, I tried and probably looked quite silly doing so. Whatever it is, the skill, like my class, is a mystery that will have to wait.

I sigh as I carefully walk across the dirt forest path near Durene's house. It's been a while since I've been by myself, and to be honest, I needed this break. My lovely host has been fussing over me all day, and she didn't even want to let me go out on my own.

That was an argument she was never going to win. Her concern is touching, but I'm hardly a quadriplegic; I need to stretch my legs and I hate being chaperoned all of the time. It's fairly easy to keep track of the dirt

path, and I'm hardly about to wander off that far. Durene showed me the route, and I have it memorized.

"What a mess."

It really is. I've gotten used to living in this world thanks to Durene, but now a bunch of questions are circling around in my head. How can I get back home? Is it even possible?

Durene is convinced that whatever happened to me was the result of magic. I tend to agree, but if any normal spell could teleport me across worlds, I'll eat my hat. No, something big happened that dragged me here, and I need to find out what.

And I won't be able to do that in Riverfarm. I need to go out into the world. A lone, blind guy in a world full of monsters and magic.

That would be my death. But it's different for an [Emperor], isn't it? What's the difference between a blind man and a blind [Emperor]?

Maybe everything. Because one of them is an [Emperor].

Norton I of America. Do you know why I loved his story? Because he was the Emperor of the United States in his head, and nothing could take that away from him.

Being blind sometimes sucks. For me it's normal, but there are days when I grow frustrated. Frustrated because other people can do things so effortlessly that I struggle to do. I'll never catch a ball, or drive, or even paint. I can't experience some of the things people talk about.

It's a bit unfair. And when I was young, I hated the way I was treated. Sometimes, yes, sometimes, I felt like less of a person because people thought of me that way. Here's a blind kid. *He* can't appreciate this, or do that. He's different. Not the same.

But I am blind. I have my own worth, regardless of whether people acknowledge that.

I stop walking. Here I am, in a forest I can't see. In a world totally different from my own. Some might say that it's not that different for someone who can't see, but I can sense the difference in every step I take. I feel the same wonder when I hear a new bird's call, or touch Durene's hands and know that *she* is different.

I am an [Emperor]. No one can take that from me. I may have gotten that class easily—just by declaring myself so. But I believed in it, even so. I believed. When you are blind, sometimes the world is uncertain. I have to

trust when I get up and walk around my house that everything is the way I left it.

I trust the things I touch with my cane, just like a seeing person trusts their eyes. But I am prepared for the times when I miss a branch or something with my cane and walk right into a shrub. I am ready, in short, to walk off a cliff some days because I can't ever be 100% certain something is right in front of me. But I have to believe I'll step onto solid ground.

So believe this: I am an [Emperor]. I should start acting like one rather than worrying about what it means.

What should I do, then? What would an [Emperor] do? I think for a while as I continue my slow amble through the forest.

"I am an [Emperor]. Ergo, everything I want to do is what an [Emperor] would do. There are no wrong choices."

But are there even more *right* ones? I remember studying Charlemagne's history. The man was an imperialist; as far as I can recall he was more or less personally involved in wars of conquest. And yet, he also instituted huge reforms across his empire.

So did Norton, at least in theory. He wanted to abolish Congress to safeguard his empire, and rumors have it that he actually stood in front of a mob to protect Chinese immigrants during race riots. Regardless of whether that's historically true or not, an [Emperor] has a duty to his empire and those he rules over. He keeps them safe, protects them; makes them better.

I would like to do the same for Durene. If she is my one subject, then what can I do for her? I walk and think, and only stop when I notice Durene not-so-subtly trying to shadow me in the forest. She really can't hide at all. But she does care, which is why I like her.

I do like her a lot. I just wish she'd tell me everything.

Day 14

What would any good [Emperor] do? What would any sensible person do when finding themselves in another world, much less a game world? Today I asked Durene countless questions about Riverfarm and the world. I'd asked her a lot before, but today I compiled it all together in my head.

"So you've never really gone further than a few miles outside of the village?"

"No. Never."

Durene and I sit together, sipping from some home-brewed mint tea. It's quite strong since we're using actual mint steeped in hot water. It's a shame we can't add some honey or sugar, but Durene has neither.

She's not rich. That much is clear, although I have to dance around the topic a bit.

"So you earn a few coins from selling your crops and animals now and then. But you've never gone with the trading cart to town?"

"No."

She shifts in her seat and slurps from her tea. She's uncomfortable. I sigh.

"You know, Durene. I don't really care if you're a bit different from other people. You're a nice young woman; regardless of who you are, I won't judge you."

Silence. Then, her deep voice quavers.

"Do you—? Did someone—?"

"No. But I am smart enough to know you're hiding something. But I won't ask until you're ready. I do hope you know you can trust me, though."

"I do. I *do*! It's just—"

It sounds like she's on the verge of tears. I reach out and touch her mug instead of her fingers. Durene laughs as I make a face and find her huge hand.

"Take your time. I'm not going anywhere. Now, tell me. What's it like living here? Do you ever see any monsters?"

"Well..."

Monsters. I can't even imagine what one of them would be like. According to Durene, they're not that bad around here. Goblins are the only real nuisance, and the village immediately sends for adventurers to root them out if they're spotted nearby.

But—yeah, there is a huge difference in the amount of danger people in this world have to live with. I might worry about bears in parts of the world, or muggers, or war, but never horrible little green creatures with teeth like knives.

God, they sound creepy.

"It's bad when Goblins come. Everyone has to give money to raise a bounty on them, but it always takes the adventurers a few weeks to arrive, and I don't know what we'd do if a Goblin Chieftain ever showed up."

Goblins are apparently a bigger threat in the north part of Izril than they are the south. It's about population density, or so I'm guessing. Humans occupy more of the north than the south which belongs to Drakes and Gnolls and something called the Antinium. So monsters accordingly spring up more near the north since there's more to eat. Odd; I would have expected them to be more plentiful in places where Humans are less common, but then, these monsters aren't prey, but our predators.

Riverfarm isn't that far north—it's decently far away from the High Passes—a huge mountain range similar to the Himalayas which divide the continent in two. Apparently the nearest major city is Invril; the city of adventurers, so named because they have the largest population of adventurers active and retired on the continent.

"They've got Gold-rank teams there. You can even find Named Adventurers passing through sometimes! And they say the markets are filled with magical items and wondrous things, like the parts of dead monsters and rare gems and artifacts."

Durene's voice is filled with wonder as she describes the city. I have to confess, the image sways me as well. Of course, the adventurers that Riverfarm can afford are a far cry from those elites.

All of the villagers, including Durene, are frankly poor. Durene is especially poor, but the villagers aren't exactly rolling in wealth either. They earn a few gold coins every year when the weather is good and the crops are plentiful. At best. During the worst times they're subsistence farmers, or they're starving.

"Folks save their coins. Mister Prost saves all his coins for instance; he only spends money when he has to buy new tools or fix his wagon. He's going to have to buy a new plow horse soon; I help out, but Evera—the horse—is old. And they want to start raising pigs, but that's an investment, and they could always use more coin to fix up the house..."

"Is anyone rich in your village? The [Blacksmith]?"

"Not really. He doesn't have *that* many levels and you know, he's still a [Farmer] as well. There's another [Blacksmith] in town that has more levels. Occasionally some people from other villages come by with work, but never for more than a few silver coins at best."

"It sounds like your village does fairly well for itself."

"Some years. Last year was okay, but the year before that was hungry. If we have a bad harvest or if winter comes early, it's very hard. The villagers

do their best, but sometimes bad things happen. And ever since they took me in—”

She breaks off. I think I understand this bit. Durene is huge. She’s not necessarily fat; she doesn’t let me touch her, but I know that she can move about with surprising speed, faster than I can. So she’s probably not fat, but she is big. She eats roughly four times what I do every meal, at least.

“I try to help out a lot. But I can only pull and lift stuff. I don’t have any Skills.”

“You said you were a Level 6 [Farmer], didn’t you?”

“Yes. I’m not too low-level for my age—some people are around Level 15, but I didn’t even apprentice and I taught myself so I leveled up slower.”

“What about your father? Your mother? What did they do when you were growing up?”

Durene hesitates. I wait in silence, the empty cup of mint tea in my hands, shedding the last vestiges of warmth. Then her voice mumbles.

“Mom died when I was four. I never met my dad. He’s dead too.”

Day 16

I think Durene is still depressed after our last conversation. We don’t talk much—that is to say, not about important things. I spend most of the time helping Durene finish up her harvesting. Most of her plants are fully grown, and we pull up several pumpkins today.

She wants to get ready for the winter, although it feels perfectly fine to me right now. Then again, I don’t know this world so weather could change a lot quicker around here.

I also sense that Durene is wrestling with something in her head, most likely whether to tell me about her past. It feels like it’s on the tip of her tongue sometimes when she pauses in talking with me.

But not yet. I abide. I’ve learned patience, and in the meantime I can teach Durene some things.

“So, your heart sends blood across the rest of your body. From your head to your toes. So you could lose an arm or a leg if you made sure to stop the blood loss, but your heart is essential.”

Durene scratches at her head.

“But doesn’t the heart get tired? I get tired from walking all day. How can a heart keep beating all the time?”

I grin.

“It’s the strongest muscle in our bodies. And it *does* get tired. People have heart attacks—times where the heart stops—as they get older. There’s a reason we can’t live forever; our bodies start breaking down as things stop working.”

“Oh. That makes sense.”

“I don’t know how old people get in this world, but the oldest people from my world are around a hundred years old. Rarely more than that.”

“A hundred? That’s a lot! Old man Schnel died when he was 62, and he was *old*.”

“Well, some things affect how old you’ll grow. Some of it is just chance or your body, but what you eat, how you live—all of that can affect your health. Like food. Remember what I said about a balanced meal?”

“Um...”

It’s fun teaching Durene the basics of biology, science, and so on. I didn’t really feel like math was that important and her speaking skills are good—she can’t write though, and I can’t help her with that.

No one taught her. But I will. Not everything will be necessarily that practical, but I hope some of it will help. Durene drinks down all of my lessons like a sponge as we harvest and cook. Helping her grow is something that makes me happy. It’s what an [Emperor] would do. What I will do.

Day 17

More harvesting. Apparently, the other villagers are also making their last harvests of the season. They might get one more yield from their crops, but maybe not. We’re storing a lot of Durene’s goods in the cellar.

...I had no idea her house *had* a cellar, but she has a rather large root cellar outside! That’s one of the things that blows me away; I would have never guessed there was a trapdoor right over there.

Day 19

I leveled up last night! I am now a Level 2 [Emperor]. What triggered the change? Durene has no idea, but I think I know. She’s my subject. Teaching her and tending to this small cottage which I claimed as my own

is the same as improving my empire, all of it in fact. It's all about perception. Perhaps there is a limit to how much exp I'd get this way, but for now I'll take what I can get.

No idea what the extra level will do for me, though. I haven't gotten any skills and still haven't figured out the [Aura of the Emperor] yet.

Hmm...

Day 20

I wake up when I hear the oddest sound. Footsteps; Durene's. Crunching.

Now, footsteps are generally easy for me. I can tell some people apart by how they walk. There's a tempo to their pace, and of course weight makes their footsteps sound different too. Durene is clearly distinct.

But what is she stepping *on*? It can't be what I think it is.

"Snow?"

It is snow! Apparently the entire world decided to up and change as I slept. Durene tells me the Winter Sprites must have brought snow to the region, which makes me wonder if she doesn't understand how the weather works.

But no—apparently in this world, weird dancing lights known as Winter Sprites can manipulate the weather. They're also a bit of a hazard, according to Durene. They'll throw snow at you if you bother them or play tricks.

That doesn't quite make sense, but the important thing is clear: it's winter. And oh boy, it's *cold*!

I help Durene strike some sparks into the fireplace of her cottage. She had to run outside for some firewood early in the morning.

"I usually keep a pile inside, but I forgot to this year. The wood's a bit wet, but I think it'll light."

Durene sneezes after she says this. She sounds cold. And there's an unpleasant amount of chill in her house without a roaring fire in her fireplace. I said her home was cozy, but it's apparent that Durene could use a better house, like the ones in the village perhaps.

Frustrating. That's what it is. I help make a thick soup while Durene clears snow, brings in chopped firewood and so on, and we have a hearty

meal. But I can't help but feel like I am a drag now that snow is making it practically impossible for me to find my way around outside.

It takes a while for the fire to start, but once it does we're warm again. Durene claims she can chop enough wood for the winter and she's hopeful about food—she says she had a good harvest, but this is living closer to the edge than I'd like. There are no supermarkets here.

At least we have some winter clothes. The villagers sent some clothes up with Prost's wife, Yesel. She came by around midday, with some coats and other garments for me. Good thing too—I was getting tired of my one set of clothes.

Etiquette demands we offer her something to eat and some of the now wonderfully warm mint tea. I chat with Yesel; she's quite happy to chatter on with me while Durene listens. It's very nice, but I sense the way she talks to Durene. And the way she hints to me.

"We'd be happy to put you up in our home for a few days. Just until the first chill goes away. The children could squeeze together in one room I'm sure."

She's not even really hinting. She's flat out telling me she wants me to go back with her into the village. And Durene's clearly unhappy about it, but she doesn't want to object.

I sip my tea calmly. What's the best answer here? Well, clearly: no.

"I'm sorry Miss Yesel, but Durene's made such a nice place for me—we just got the second cot set up. I'd love to join you for a meal or two later, but for now I feel I should stay here. I'd hate to be out on the road in my condition, you know."

"Oh yes. I've made a good spot for myself, Miss Yesel. And I can get everything Laken needs here—"

"I'm sure you have, Durene."

Yesel interrupts Durene politely. I get the feeling she's not actually smiling, but her tone sounds friendly as she reaches out to touch my hand. I jerk and she takes her hand back. I *hate* it when people touch me without warning me.

"Do excuse me. But I'm sure we could get Durene to pull the wagon if you don't want to walk. It would only be a few minutes' trip."

So polite. So friendly. I can feel the invisible looks she's giving Durene. My skin prickles, but I smile in her direction.

“Nevertheless, I’d truly hate to take over your rooms. Kids should have a lot of space, and I wouldn’t want to cramp you all.”

Now she’s hesitating. I know for a fact that my poker face is perfect; but she can’t quite tell if I’m innocently being obtuse or refusing her. Now she takes a different tack.

“Well—the Beetrs have also said they’d be delighted if you came over for dinner. And they have an empty room after their daughter sadly passed away last summer. You could join them. What do you think?”

“Mm...well...”

“It would be so much larger than here. I know Durene has done her best, but isn’t this a tiny bit too small for two people?”

“I—I could sleep outside! Or in the root cellar. I’m fine with—”

“I actually like the closeness, in fact.”

This time it’s my turn to interrupt Durene. I smile placidly, although I’m getting more and more annoyed by the second. I can sense Yesel reacting across the table.

“I think I’m fine, I really am, Miss Yesel. Durene is an excellent hostess. She’s helped me out immeasurably and I have every confidence that she will continue to do so.”

Durene’s silent, possibly embarrassed, and Yesel is quiet. Then she speaks to Durene directly.

“Durene? Why don’t you go fetch us some more firewood? I’m sure Mister Laken is feeling quite chilly.”

I bite my lip as Durene rises without a word to do as Yesel says. *Mister Laken* is feeling fine, thanks. And Durene shouldn’t have to obey someone else’s order in her own home.

But because Yesel is giving us a gift and because I don’t have the full picture—not yet—I listen. Yesel leans forwards to talk to me as I hear Durene moving about outside.

“Durene is a good child, Mister Laken. Sometimes. But we put her out here so she wouldn’t cause trouble if—has she told you what she is?”

“No. I believe she will tell me when she feels comfortable.”

“Yes, but—I think you don’t quite understand what the problem is.”

I raise one eyebrow.

“Problem? I haven’t had a problem with Durene, Miss Yesel. Unless you think otherwise?”

“No...”

She says it, clearly meaning the opposite. I hear a slurp, and then her voice again.

“But some of us in the village—Durene was wonderfully good about taking you in, but she’s not someone that should be kept cooped up with you—with someone like you—all winter. It would be better for everyone if you stayed in the village. We’d love to have you.”

And I’d probably hate it there. I listen to Durene lifting something with a grunt, and then shake my head.

“I have no problems with Durene, Miss Yesel. I will stay here.”

Now frustration enters the other woman’s voice.

“I really don’t think that’s wise. Durene is—”

“—Is Durene. I think that’s what you meant to say, Miss Yesel. Please don’t say anything else. I prefer to let people keep their secrets.”

“But—!”

This has gone on long enough. I stand up.

“Good day, Miss Yesel. Thank you for the clothes.”

There’s not much she can say after that. I practically chase her out, and Durene, covered in snow and bewildered, barely gets to say goodbye.

Okay, maybe it was rude to bundle the woman off so fast, but she was being incredibly rude. I know Durene has a secret, but why wouldn’t they trust her with me? I’ve slept under her roof for over two weeks now without a problem.

It’s cozy and warm in Durene’s cottage after Yesel leaves. I’m perfectly content, and Durene is almost pathetically relieved that I’m staying. She keeps chattering nervously about everything but what that conversation meant.

It occurs to me later what the problem is. I don’t have a problem with Durene, no matter who she really is. But Yesel and the other villagers don’t like that I don’t care.

Not one bit.

Day 22

I’ve just begun to adjust to the new circumstances of freezing weather. It’s impossible for me to really find my way around outside without Durene, but we can still go walking in the snow. Of course, I have to be bundled up like a sausage, but that’s okay.

And it's not like we lack things to do inside. There's still so much that no one ever taught Durene—whether because this world doesn't have any standard of education or because no one taught her specifically, and I enjoy talking with her.

But sometimes we do crave the outside, if only to perform vital tasks. Despite the decent construction, Durene's outhouse freezes all my bits the moment I try to do my business. That makes everything slower, but she waits patiently for me as I attempt to speed up my natural body processes.

That's when I hear the laughter, and the malicious voices. Children—the village children—come running up the path towards Durene's cottage as I sit in the outhouse.

"Freak! Come out, Freak!"

"There she is! Get her!"

It's like listening to a movie, only I'm sitting in a freezing-cold movie theatre and I don't have a bag of popcorn. And this is real, so my heart immediately pounds harder when I hear Durene's voice.

"Ow! Stop!"

What's happening? I hear *paffs*, the sound of snow hitting—

Snowballs. Those little bastards are throwing snowballs! From the sounds outside Durene isn't doing anything, just trying to shield herself. But the children are laughing.

"Get her! She's a [Witch]!"

"She's tricking the blind man! Let's slay the Freak!"

"I'm not! I—ow!"

More laughter, and the sounds of more snowballs being thrown. I fumble with my pants, trying to think of what to do as the situation outside escalates.

Those—there's a difference between having fun and being malicious little demons. I have to do something. But what?

For a few seconds, I worry about consequences and repercussions. Durene has her own relationship with the villagers. Who am I to interfere with that?

Who am I?

An [Emperor].

Oh.

Of course.

How could I have forgotten? This house is my empire; Durene is my subject. And those annoying little brats are harassing her. I have a duty to her.

I don't quite kick the outhouse door open, but I do push it out with more force than normal. Frankly, I'd hate to break the door even in my anger. No one wants to have wind and ice flecks blown right at their private parts in the midst of an intimate moment.

The laughter cuts off as soon as I step into the snow. I turn in the direction of the kids.

"Hey. You lot. Stop that."

Not exactly fighting words, but I'm deadly serious. And these are just kids. I hear uncomfortable shifting, and then voices.

"What should we—?"

"He don't know nothing! He's blind!"

"Yeah! We gotta chase away the Freak!"

I point in their direction.

"I don't appreciate bullying. Keep away from Durene. If you little bastards throw snow at her again, there *will* be consequences."

For two seconds I think that will work. Then one of the children laughs uncertainly. He jeers at me.

"You can't do nothing! You can't see!"

"Yeah! He likes the Freak more than real people!"

"Get him!"

Something flies past my face and I flinch back. Crap. Suddenly all the animosity of the gang of children is transferred at me. A snowball filled with ice bursts against my coat and I wonder what I should do next.

"*Stop that!*"

Something huge interposes itself between me and the children. I feel Durene protectively shielding me.

"Look! The Freak's in the way!"

"Get her!"

"Throw these! Eat pinecones, Freak!"

Something bounces off Durene and she yelps. That's when I lose my temper.

"Enough."

I push Durene aside and the word comes out of me like a shout. But it's not quite a shout. It's...something else.

The rage burning in my chest ignites, and it attaches to the word. It bursts out, and I feel it leave like a physical thing.

What happened? What did I just do?

I hear screams, and then the sound of someone throwing up. Then I hear footsteps, running, confusion, screams—

Then silence.

“Durene? What’s going on?”

I reach out and touch a thick back covered with cloth. I feel Durene’s cold skin shivering, and then she takes my hand with her callused palms.

“Laken? I—I don’t know. You did something just now. The kids—they’ve all run off!”

“I did that?”

I must have. And it must be—

“[Aura of the Emperor]. Durene, tell me what happened.”

We stand in the snow as Durene tries to relate what happened. According to her, it was suddenly as if I shouted and something *hit* the kids. She felt a presence—and sudden fear. But what I did wasn’t aimed at her, so it was brief.

The children clearly had a more violent reaction. They made tracks. I don’t know what I did, not exactly, but I can guess.

“I was angry. Seriously pissed. I must have used that to scare them. The aura—I might be able to use that in other ways as well.”

I can remember the sensation. It was physical; like sending part of myself out into the world. It was amazing, and terrifying. I’ve never felt like that before, but I’m glad.

Yes, I’m glad I did it. And so is Durene. In her own way!

“You shouldn’t have done that. You shouldn’t have! There will be trouble—”

“If there is, we’ll be causing the trouble. Those children had no right to harass you.”

“But that’s just them being...”

“That’s them being intolerant idiots. I won’t let anyone do that again. It stops now.”

How? All I know is that I mean every word as Durene and I dry off. How would I stop those kids, outside of using that skill again?

Fence? Too hard, and they’d just climb over it or get around it somehow. Bear trap? Probably not.

“I suppose we could just bury them in the snow head-first next time they come by. I’ll hold their legs; you dig the hole.”

Durene giggles nervously, and I smile as I tell more jokes to make her laugh. But I can’t help but feel like I’ve started something.

I’m right. Not thirty minutes later, I hear someone approaching. Durene tenses up and she tells me Prost has come by. We invite him in, and he gets to business in a matter of seconds.

“The kids say you did something, Mister Laken. They weren’t hurt none although they’re fair terrified. But we’d like to know what happened.”

“Oh, you know, Mister Prost. I heard them throwing snowballs and pine cones at Durene and had a word with them. We can’t have children going around attacking people, can we?”

“No, I suppose not. Still, that was a bit of a thing to do over a little thing like that, wasn’t it? I’m sure the children didn’t mean nothing by it. They tease Durene, but there’s nothing in it.”

I keep my voice light and friendly, like a calm before the storm.

“I’m sure you’re right, Mister Prost. I’m sure they didn’t meant anything by the snowballs. Or the name calling.”

He shifts, and I hear Durene swallow.

“Mister Laken, you seem like a nice enough young man. But there’s something you don’t know about Durene.”

“So I’ve been told by you, the children, and your wife. I thought I made it quite clear that I don’t care.”

“Nevertheless, sir. Durene’s different.”

“Mister Prost—!”

I can almost feel Durene shrinking back. And now I’m even angrier than I was at the kids.

“Stop that. Yes, you, Mister Prost. Durene has been nothing but friendly to me since I arrived here. Your children on the other hand attacked her, and then me.”

“I know that sir, and I’ll make sure they remember it. They won’t be walking straight, you have my promise. But Durene—”

“What is your problem with her?”

I snap. I can’t help it.

“Durene is different. I get that. But what does that matter? She’s a friend. My friend. If she has a secret, she will tell me *herself*. Now, I think it’s time you leave.”

Prost hesitates, but he doesn't get up.

"You might think Durene is fine, but you don't see her like we do. Now, Durene, you're a good enough girl, but—"

I stand up.

"Enough. I think you should leave, Mister Prost. Now."

The other man stands up. He's angry, now.

"You don't understand the situation, *Mister Laken*. Durene's our village's problem, and she was easy enough to manage before this."

"I—"

I'd almost forgotten Durene was in the room. She sounds like a mouse—a big one—as she tries to speak.

"I'm not doing anything! I just want to help Laken!"

The other man's voice is flat as he replies.

"You don't belong with our kind. You help—but we keep you away for a reason. Remember your father? If his kind came back or you lost control—you're not like us, Durene. And Mister Laken doesn't know that!"

"He likes me! He doesn't care! Why is that so bad?"

For once Durene is arguing back. I don't respond and let her raise her voice. But now Prost is shouting.

"Don't you raise your voice to me! Who do you think took you in, fed you? We risked our necks for you!"

"You only did that because my mother asked you to! And you gave me scraps! I had to sleep in the barn with the other animals! I never—never ate with you all! And now you're trying to take away my only *friend*!"

Now it comes out. Durene's voice is filled with emotion, and I can hear her hands cracking the wood of her table as she grips it. There's a *crack*, and I feel the table I'm sitting at break.

Prost knocks over his chair and retreats to the door. Durene's on her feet—not advancing—but I get up before anyone can act.

"That's enough. Prost, it's time for you to go. I'm staying here with Durene, and nothing you tell me is going to change that."

"But you don't understand!"

It sounds like Prost is nearly tearing out his hair—if he has any—in frustration. But he's afraid of Durene as well, I can tell.

Durene's voice is cold.

"If that's what Laken says, he stays. I'll take care of him here. Now, you've gotta leave, Mister Prost. This is my house, and you're not welcome

here any longer.”

She advances, and I hear the man rush out the door. I follow Durene out, and hear Prost’s voice. He’s far away from us but shouting.

“Do you know what she *is*!? She’s a monster! A freak!”

My pulse is boiling in my veins. I glare in his direction.

“*I don’t care*. Go away and stop bothering us!”

“You don’t know anything, boy! She’s tricking you by acting friendly, but her kind can’t be trusted! She’s a monster. She’s not Human she’s a—”

“A Troll!”

The word doesn’t come from Prost’s mouth. It comes from Durene, a shout. My heart skips a beat, and then I hear her shouting.

“*Troll!* There! I said it! Troll, Troll, *Troll!*”

Her voice is huge. Huge and deep, and it’s so loud I swear snow is falling from the trees. She *screams* at Prost, leaving the man speechless.

“Why can’t you let me have this? Why did you have to *tell* him? What harm would it have done if I—”

Durene is crying, sobbing as she shouts as loudly as she can. She rails against Prost, cursing him. I hear an impact and sense she’s fallen to her knees. In the next silence I listen and hear distant crunching in the snow.

“He’s running.”

Coward. My heart is beating too fast, and I feel something clenching at it. I’m furious, but right now Durene is more important.

Slowly, I step forwards towards her, reaching my hand out. I touch her—and her rough skin slides under my fingertips. She makes no move; only sobbing as I slowly touch her.

Arm. Rough arm, practically bursting the seams of her clumsily-sewn clothing. And then up to her shoulder, twice as broad as mine. Her muscle is as dense as a rock, and her skin feels like an elephant’s hide.

Then her neck, her head. It’s like a Human’s but big enough for her body. Her nose is...wide, and she has eyebrows. And hair. Long and coarser than Human hair, but not by much.

That’s the secret. That’s what she feared. Her terrible, meaningless, sad secret. But she told one lie, and as I touch her face, I know. I see everything.

I murmur the words into the snow as I touch her tears.

“Half-Troll.”

[Emperor Level 4!]

[Skill – King’s Bounty obtained!]

Day 23

Troll. What do you think of when you hear that word? I’m told that movies have wonderful images of Trolls, but I have obviously never seen them.

So I can only work off the descriptions of Trolls I’ve read in stories. When I first read *The Hobbit*, my notion of Trolls were these slightly bigger-than-average Humans with cockney accents and weird names. One of them was called Bert, for goodness sake!

But then I listened to The Lord of the Rings movie, and my idea of Trolls was different. The idea of some massive, grey humanoid creature that roared and swung a club around fixed itself in my head. Even when I read the descriptions of green Trolls with noxious odors, the image of the Troll with stone-like skin and savage, dimwitted rage stayed with me.

That is not Durene. So when I listened to her, I threw away all the notions and preconceptions I had about Trolls. All of them. I put the stories I’d heard in a box and tossed it out, because she deserves to tell me who she is rather than have me judge her before I know her.

And I do know Durene. She isn’t violent. She isn’t angry. And from what she tells me, neither are Trolls.

“I didn’t know my father. He was—he was a wandering Troll, and I think he met my mom during the Spring. He was hungry and she was living by herself and—”

Trolls are monsters. Everyone considers them as such, apparently. They don’t have a civilization like Drakes or Gnolls, but they are smarter than your average monster. Smart as a Goblin, which might not be saying much. I don’t know. But not all Trolls are violent.

“He must not have been hungry, because he didn’t eat my mom. Not all Trolls eat...people.”

We sit together in Durene’s home as she tells me everything. The fire crackles, but aside from that, everything else is quiet. I sit silently at her broken table, listening as Durene’s low voice speaks into the silence.

She’s done crying. All the grief and fear of last night is gone, and now the truth comes out of her. All the things she wanted to tell me, spilling out.

I can feel the fear in her voice, that I'll judge her, run from her. Fear her. I listen to it all in silence.

"Mom was living alone, away from the others. She'd been married—I think she'd had a husband before, and another kid. But she lost both so she had a small farm by herself. And Dad was hungry, so she found him in her fields. And I guess she must have liked him, or gotten to know him somehow, because a few weeks later she was pregnant."

"That's how they met?"

Durene shifts.

"I don't know. Mom never said, and the villagers just said that Miss Yesel came up one day and found her pregnant and alone. And Troll tracks nearby. I think that's how it happened. I hope it is. Otherwise..."

Otherwise, her mother was attacked by a Troll. And Durene will never know which is true, because her mother is dead and none of the other villagers were there. But they speculated, and Durene probably grew up hearing that speculation.

"Anyways, they let Mom stay, but an adventurer heard about a Troll and came to kill it. He—he did. And afterwards, he wanted to kill me too, but Mom wouldn't let him."

"Did she raise you alone?"

"She tried. But after I was born she was so weak because I was too big—and she never fully got better. She died when I was four. After that, the village took me in, but I didn't really have a home."

Sleeping in a barn. Fed scraps. I can only imagine what it was like.

"When I was bigger, I made my home here, where Mom used to live. I've been living here since, and the villagers only call me when they need help. I was alone, and I'd hide every time adventurers came by. I hid from other people too, in case they thought I was dangerous. Until I met you."

I get it. The crying in the woods, the hope that I wouldn't immediately judge her, the villagers wanting to separate me from the potentially dangerous half-monster.

It all makes sense. It's such a predictable story in some ways.

And it's such crap. Durene doesn't deserve any of this.

I choose my words carefully in the silence after Durene's confession. I really don't know what to say, but I know what *not* to say.

"Durene. I'm sorry all of this has happened to you. But it doesn't change anything for me."

She gulps.

“Laken. I—I’m sorry I lied.”

“That’s okay.”

“No. It’s not. I should have told you. And you don’t have to—to say nice things. You can leave. I’ll bring you into the village and apologize.”

“Why would I do that?”

Pause.

“What?”

“I’m staying here. With you.”

“But—”

“You being half-Troll doesn’t change anything. I told you that, remember? I got to know you, and that means I won’t run away just because you’re not Human.”

“I—you don’t understand. I’m half *Troll*. Adventurers would kill me on sight. If I were in a town or a city I’d probably have a bounty put on my head!”

“Probably. But that doesn’t mean I’ll go. It’s okay, Durene.”

“No! Stop being so nice!”

“Durene, calm down. I’m not upset.”

“I know! But—it’s not nothing! Stop being so *nice* to me! What I am—I’m not Human! I’m not normal! Don’t pretend you don’t care!”

“I care. But I know you.”

“No you don’t. You can’t see—you’d never trust me if you could see.”

“That’s what the villagers have told you. But they’re wrong. They look at you and see a monster but they are wrong. They. Are. Wrong. Do you understand that, Durene?”

“...I can’t. No.”

“Durene? Where are you going? Durene? *Durene!*”

I’m on my feet as the door slams open. The cold winds of winter rush in, and I hear massive footsteps thumping away. I run after her, shouting.

“Durene!”

Only after I’m outside does it occur to me that maybe I should have given Durene more space. She’s right; I was treating this like nothing. I should have shown more of the surprise swirling inside of me.

But I didn’t want to hurt her feelings and I still meant what I said. How could a girl that nice and caring be a monster?

And now I'm running through the snow, without my cane. I slow the instant I realize that.

Oh shit. The snow is deep around me, I can't see, and there is nothing like a path that I can follow.

I'm lost.

For a few seconds I just turn, trying to look for my tracks in the snow. But I can't find them. I shout for Durene, but she's not coming back. I'm by myself, and I can already feel the cold piercing my clothing.

This is probably a blind person's worst fear. Without any tools I can barely find my way around, and without people or landmarks in this freezing weather—I'm so dead.

I start walking forwards, trying to feel for anything that reminds me of Durene's cottage. I don't have a choice. Either I could stay and hope Durene comes back—and she could be gone for hours—or I try to return to the cottage.

I only ran a little bit outside. But that distance could be miles as far as I'm concerned. This damn snow! It's falling from the skies and making everything unfamiliar. Even my tracks—I try to kick up as much snow so I can find my way back.

Okay. Let's go...ten steps this way. No? I feel nothing familiar, so I try to retrace my steps. I find my tracks and get back to roughly where I thought I was before. Now this way. No?

...Where did my tracks go? I spin around, confused. The snow—it's too thick! I bend down, but my hands feel only the same level of snow around me. It's as if I never started walking in the first place.

Oh no. I'm starting to panic. I stumble forwards, feeling my way ahead.

Gah! Damn it, I just ran into a *tree*. That's bad. I'm in the forest. I try to turn back, but I'm not 100% sure I'm not going further into the forest.

Another tree. And now I'm trying to listen for anything that can help me find my way to Durene's cottage.

I might die out here. I take a deep breath.

"Durene! I'm lost out here! Can yo—"

I trip. My world shifts and I hit the ground hard. Something just caught my foot! Not a tree root—

I scramble back towards whatever it was in the snow. I'm praying that I tripped over one of Durene's plants and I'm in her garden.

It's not a plant. It's not anything like a plant. Instead, as my aching foot could attest, the object is heavy and partially buried in the ground. I feel at it.

Not a rock...the outside is rough and coarse. A bag? Yes! I can feel the opening here, and two drawstrings. Curious now, despite the cold, I undo the strings.

Is this some kind of bag of fertilizer? But no, why would that...

Hold on. My fingers encounter something hard in the bag and jerk away. I touch again. Something *clinks* as I shift it.

Round, hard, circular objects. Lots of them. I feel them, lifting one up and dropping it.

"What the hell...?"

Clink. Clink.

There's only one thing that makes that kind of beguiling, attractive sound. And the weight of it! I pull at the bag, but I can't even get it to shift in the frozen ground.

Is this what I think it is? Really?

"Laken! LAKEN!"

I hear someone shouting my name in the distance. Immediately I stand up and bellow back.

"Durene? Over here!"

Immediately, I hear crashing through the woods. Branches splinter off Durene as she crashes towards my location, showering me with snow. I splutter and then feel two arms around me.

"I'm sorry! I'm so sorry! I didn't realize you were out here!"

"It's okay! Durene! You're squishing me!"

Immediately she lets go. I gasp for air—I'd heard of a bear hug, but this is the first time I actually felt someone literally squashing me.

"Sorry!"

"It's okay. I'm really glad you found me. Durene, I'm sorry."

"No, I—"

I grasp her arm. She falls silent, and I do too. For a few seconds, I just listen to my heart beating, and hear snow softly falling in the background. Durene's skin is rough under my palms. Rough, but not unpleasant.

"This is the first time I've really touched you, you know."

"Really?"

"Really. You've helped me along, but I normally grab your clothes."

And she never let me touch her before that. I feel Durene gulp as I hold her.

“Oh.”

We stand like that in silence for a little while. Then I feel the chill seeping into my bones.

“I guess we should go back.”

“Right! Let me carry you.”

Durene wants to lift me up, but I shake my head.

“I found something in the ground. Can you pull it up?”

“In the ground? Where?”

It takes me a few seconds to find it. Durene covered it when she ran over. But when I show Durene she lifts it up. It sounds like she’s uprooting a huge amount of soil and I cover my face as some of it flies at me.

“What’s this bag? I’ve never—oh.”

Her voice goes silent all of a sudden. I feel around, and then find the bag in her hands. I reach into the open top and pick out two of the heavy little circular things within.

“Hey Durene. Would you mind telling me what you see? I don’t want to get ahead of myself, but...”

I tap the round object against the second one and hear that delightful chime of metal on metal. Each coin is *heavy*, and as I weigh them in my hand I notice the rough, smooth stones in the sack as well. Well, well, well.

“I could be wrong, but I hope I’m not. Because unless I’m very much mistaken, this is a gold coin. And this would be buried treasure.”

I’m remarkably calm about that bit. That is, until we get back to the cottage and start counting.

“It’s all gold!”

Durene exclaims as I place another coin on the careful stack of five on the table. I have to move carefully so as not to knock over my stacks, but with Durene’s help we’ve tallied the contents of the mysterious sack at last.

“One hundred and forty one gold coins and eight gemstones.”

I sit back in my chair and reach for the mug of tea. Durene pushes it into my hands and I savor the warmth. I still feel a bit cold after my little exploration outside.

“It’s a fortune. A huge fortune! Where did it come from?”

“I have my suspicions.”

I can sense Durene's curiosity. I smile. The treasure I found managed to calm Durene down. She forgot about her woes to bask in the radiance of gold. Myself, I can't see the appeal. It's just heavy metal to me, but I'm told it's quite valuable.

And in this case, it's literally more money than Durene has ever seen in her life. By her estimates, I could literally buy Riverfarm six times over. At least. She has no idea where the money came from, and I tend to doubt that someone would just leave a fortune in the ground like that. But there might be another explanation for my good fortunes.

"[King's Bounty]. It has to be my Skill."

It tickles my sense of humor a bit that I got a skill probably meant for [Kings]. I didn't really have time to even wonder what it meant, but this is a pretty good sign of what the Skill does.

"You mean you got money because of a Skill?"

"Perhaps. It might be that I *can't* be poor if I have [King's Bounty] as a Skill. You know, like how a [King] should never be poor? Haven't you heard of something like that happening before?"

"No. Never! But—I have heard of [Treasure Hunters] that can find buried treasure. But why would an [Emperor] have that skill?"

"Perhaps because any ruler should have money? Doesn't it make sense that the Skill would be doing this?"

"Yes, but Skills aren't normally this powerful! Not at early levels!"

"Right. You mentioned that. Normally people received weaker skills the lower level they are. Only when they're above Level 30 do the skills become powerful, right? But maybe this *is* a crummy skill for an [Emperor] by comparison."

"I can't believe it. I can't."

"It's certainly useful, although I wonder how we'll spend it. There's not exactly a lot of shops around here."

"We?"

"I told you Durene, I'm staying with you. And you helped me dig this thing up. Without you, I would have frozen out there in a few more minutes."

"But—"

"Durene."

I reach out and touch her. This time I get one of her sides. She freezes, but I trace my hands upwards. I find her face, and feel her trembling.

“Durene. I’m going nowhere. And I don’t care if you’re half-Troll or half-Goblin or half-Frog. You are who you are, and I like you for that. You can run, and I might not be able to follow you in the snow, but when you come back, I’ll be waiting. So why not just stay?”

I feel silly, and I’m sure what I said didn’t make too much sense. But Durene trembles, and I feel wetness at my fingers.

“I don’t know what to do. I want you to stay, Laken. I do. But what if—what will the others say?”

“What they say is their business. Not yours. I’m asking you if I can stay here, Durene.”

“Yes. Please.”

“Then that’s settled, then.”

“But you and I. I don’t know what I should—I must be so strange to you.”

“Only a bit. But that’s because I don’t know you just yet. I know a lot but...Durene. Will you let me touch you? I can’t see, but I want to get to know you.”

“You—what if you hate me?”

“I never would.”

“Then—can I touch you?”

“Of course.”

A rough hand, a finger gently brushes against my face. It feels as light as a feather. I feel at Durene’s face, tracing the contours of her features, trying to understand her in my own way. She touches me, gently, as if she’s never touched another living thing before.

Slowly, I work my way down from her face. Durene shivers, but her touch is just as light. I am curious, and so is she. There’s no words, but I think we understand each other completely in that moment.

No more secrets. No more hidden truths and untrue and unkind words. Just a light touch; an intimate question whispered from one person to another.

And there’s more touching, but I won’t talk too much about that. The snow falls heavily, as inside, Durene and I explore one another. We are who we are. No more.

No less.

Day 24

I feel like I shouldn't share much of this day either. Let's just say that today the pile of gold and jewels went nearly completely untouched, until we accidentally knocked the table over. Turns out gold coins *hurt* when they're dropped on your body.

Day 25

Mm. More of the same, really. But we talked about the future. We talked, and I made her laugh. As we did before. As I hope to do.

Day 27

A bunch of kids called out for Durene as she and I were having breakfast. They needed help; a roof had collapsed in the village under the weight of the snow and the villagers needed Durene to lift a beam.

I told her not to go. Durene wanted to help. In the end, I waited for her to return. When she did, she was upset.

Tears, hot and wet, fall on my fingertips. Durene's skin feels a bit like cracked stone as I brush against her cheek. Swords or arrows would have a hard time piercing her skin.

But words? Words cut deepest of all.

"I don't know what to do. I'm not a monster! But they just think I'm like my father. I don't know what to do. Laken..."

Neither do I. But I can't bear to see her crying.

"I can't do anything. Just lift things. Like an animal. That's all I do. I can't build or cook. I can barely grow things—"

"Shh."

It takes her a long time to get to sleep, but eventually it happens. I sit up, anger and sadness fighting like snakes in my belly. What can I do? What could—

What could I do for *her*?

And then I have it.

Day 28

"Is it like a [Knight]?"

“Almost. But better. After all, any ordinary monarch can make a [Knight]. But only an [Emperor] can give someone this class.”

Durene shifts next to me. I hold her hand, and feel her quiver.

“I’m not sure I’m a warrior.”

“Are you a [Farmer]?”

“No. I don’t think so.”

“Then try this. They weren’t always warriors. Culture just interpreted them that way after a while. Before that they were just servants. Great warriors, true, but they served Charlemagne in more ways than just in combat. I think.”

I haven’t actually spent that much time studying the etymology of that class, even though I once played as one in a D&D session. Oh well.

“If you want to be one, I’ll make you one.”

“Just like that? It sounds too easy.”

“It’s not. I’m the only [Emperor] on this continent; only I can choose who is worthy of this class. And of all the people in the world, there’s no one I’d want to be with me more than you, Durene.”

“I—please. I don’t want to just be a [Farmer].”

“Then, kneel.”

I feel her bend down in front of me. I reach out and place my hands on her shoulders.

“I knight you, Durene. I name you as my [Paladin], my foremost champion who will protect and serve me. Will you do this?”

“Yes.”

She whispers it, then says it louder.

“Yes!”

Something changes. Just a bit. I bend down to Durene and give her a kiss. On the forehead, then elsewhere.

“Is *that* part of being a [Paladin] too?”

I have to laugh.

“It would be a surprise if it was.”

She rises, and I feel something different about her. It’s subtle. But it comes to me as I’m sleeping. Perhaps it’s not confidence; not yet. There’s no marked change in her, no sudden shift. But there is one thing she has now that she never had. And it’s growing slowly, like one of her seeds.

A purpose.

Day 29

“I’m...I’m a [Paladin].”

So Durene says as I wake up. I smile, and hug her, and then she laughs and shouts it.

“I’m a [*Paladin*]!”

Day 30

A lot can happen in a month. In the weather’s case, the atmosphere changed from a nice, pleasantly warm fall to a blizzard-filled winter almost overnight.

Even now, it seems like the snow won’t stop falling. Twice Durene’s gone out to clear a path. She does it quickly and efficiently—even the deepest snow tends to go flying if she exerts herself.

A lot can change in a month for people as well. A young woman who would run from children and names has turned into someone else. Someone confident enough to chase away the obnoxious little monsters who tell her she *has* to help out a village full of idiots and bigots. She walks and speaks with something else in her now.

And I, I changed quite a lot as well. For one thing, the young man named Laken Godart suddenly became an [Emperor] and found someone to love. That has to be worth something.

In a small cottage a few miles outside of the village of Riverfarm, I sit. I am the Emperor of the Unseen, Protector of Durene’s House. I have one subject—or should that be consort? She is a half-Troll, a young woman named Durene.

And she is beautiful. She was a [Farmer]; now she is a [Paladin]. And what that means neither of us know. I have a bag of gold, and a village full of fools that can’t accept Durene for who she is.

I have no sight, but I have a dream. A grand one, where Durene and I leave this place that she could never call home. Or maybe we change it. But either way I know we will do it. I am an [Emperor], and for her, I would change the world.

And so we shall.

Together.

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Ceria Springwalker stared down at her skeletal hand and for a brief moment, wondered what would happen if she cast [Ice Spike] at point blank range at her face. She'd probably die instantly; in the worst case scenario the shard would lodge in her flesh and brain but fail to kill her.

It was just an idle thought, but she was half-contemplating it. Even horrible mutilation would be preferable to the current situation.

She looked up at the other two members of the Horns of Hammerad sitting around the small fire they'd built. The hazy smoke drifted up, a beacon to any monsters looking for a hot meal. Hopefully none would come; Ceria had tried to camp far enough away from the Ruins of Albez for that, but nasty surprises were always an adventurer's concern.

Across the fire, Pisces sat on the ground, mumbling quietly to himself as he reviewed his personal spellbook full of notes and spells he was studying. His robes—never too clean at the best of times—were filthy, and he reeked. In fact, he smelled so bad that even Ksmvr, who didn't really have much of a sense of smell, was sitting far away.

The Antinium had no need of flame. In fact, Ceria thought the fire bothered him a bit. Despite the cold winter weather, the former Prognugator sat with his back to the fire, scanning the landscape. He wasn't sleeping as he kept watch, but he was so still that he could have been a statue.

Neatly laid out by the Antinium's side was a shortbow and arrows planted in the ground, ready to be fired. He had one of Erin's kitchen knives on the ground in front of him, and the enchanted iron shortsword next to it. It was like Ksmvr expected an attack at any moment.

Ceria sighed. Then she stared back at her skeletal hand again. It didn't hurt. Not anymore. But it felt like it was still covered in flesh, sometimes. But she had to use magic—let it flow into her missing limb—to make it move. And when she touched things, that was the worst. Then she *felt* as if she could feel something, but it was just her imagination.

The fire coughed and Pisces sneezed into it. Ceria made a face as a wisp of smoke drifted her way. Pisces really did need a bath. She could probably

conjure some water out of the air, but it would be a waste of mana. Plus, if she was going to clean him she might as well start with herself.

Ceria wasn't a stranger to roughing it. She'd spent countless nights outside before she passed her second decade, and she'd gone on countless expeditions with the original Horns of Hammerad, tracking monsters, preparing for dungeon dives, and so on.

But she couldn't remember camping out ever being this pitiful. Ceria knew that she smelled about half as bad as Pisces, and dried sweat, grime, and unwashed clothing was making her own personal experience unpleasant.

At least they weren't camping in the snow again. Ceria and Pisces had cleared the ground of the stuff, and it wasn't snowing like it had last night. Normally Ceria would have liked to camp in a cave, but the Ruins of Albez were part of a natural depression in the ground far from any helpful mountains or hills. The ruined building had sunk into the earth, and so any normal group of adventurers planning to stay in the area for more than one day brought tents.

But they didn't have any, because they couldn't afford them. In fact, the Horns of Hammerad hadn't planned on staying long in any case. They'd brought enough supplies for two days.

This was their eighth night. All of them had yet to eat.

Ceria's stomach growled and she made a face. Hunger was also something she'd gotten used to when she was young, but she couldn't ever remember really running out of food in the Horns of Hammerad. For all his temperamental issues, Calruz had been a good soldier and leader in keeping his group fed and outfitted, and Gerial had always left a margin of error when buying gear.

Her heart twinged as she remembered them. Ceria stared back into the fire as Pisces clicked his tongue. Her stomach growled again.

Only—that wasn't a growl. That was the faint *crunch* of something in the snow. Ceria instantly looked up and began focusing mana into her skeletal hand. She saw Ksmvr grab his bow and an arrow. Pisces sat in front of the fire, oblivious as he nibbled at a dirty fingernail.

"Pisces."

Ceria kept her voice low as she hissed at him. Pisces took no notice. Ceria was about to snap at him even if it meant warning whatever was approaching when she heard a voice.

“It’s me, Ceria.”

Instantly, Ceria relaxed. Ksmvr lowered his bow as Yvlon approached. The armored woman walked towards the campfire and tiredly slung a pack to the ground.

“Food and another shovel.”

She tossed the shovel on the ground as well, nearly hitting the fire. Pisces looked up and sniffed at the tool. Then he went back to reading.

Yvlon eyed the mage, and then laboriously sat down. She began trying to take off her silver armor, equally dirty from time spent outdoors. Ceria went to help; she’d helped her fellow adventurers more than once and she knew how it was done.

Ksmvr came over too. He sat respectfully away from everyone else, which was probably for the best.

“Comrade Yvlon. Does our team have permission to reenter the ruins tomorrow?”

Yvlon barely paused at Ksmvr’s odd address. She nodded tiredly.

“That’s what the City Runner said. No team wants to go to the ruins; they’re all busy with local requests or getting ready to enter that dungeon in Liscor.”

“I see. That is optimal.”

Ksmvr nodded several times. Ceria’s face didn’t really smile; her lips just sort of twisted. Yvlon was making the same face.

“Apparently, the [Dangersense] surge we felt came from that dungeon. No word on whether something else happened; mages would have gotten a message if something nasty came out.”

“Still. That’s some danger in there if *that’s* what happened from just opening the front door.”

Ceria muttered as she helped Yvlon take off the breastplate. The other woman nodded.

“More teams are coming down from the northern cities. Big names. Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers are going to have competition if they don’t clear the dungeon soon.”

“Mm.”

Ceria had too many emotions and feelings about the new dungeon to put into words. Yvlon clearly felt the same way, because she didn’t elaborate. Ceria had just finished helping her take off the last of her armor when she exclaimed in annoyance.

“*Pisces!* Get your hands out of the food!”

The young man paused as he lifted a sausage out of the bag Yvlon had brought. He sniffed at Ceria.

“I am feeding myself, Springwalker.”

“We’ll make food for everyone in a little bit. Your hands are *filthy*.”

“I am hungry.”

Yvlon didn’t say anything, but Ceria had to seriously stop herself from blasting Pisces with a spell there and then. She modulated her tone only slightly.

“We all are. But we eat and work together as a team. Put the food back.”

Pisces held her gaze for a second, and then made an irritated sound. He tossed the sausage back at the bag and missed. It landed in the dirt next to the fire.

Yvlon twitched. But she didn’t say anything. Ceria counted to five before she picked the dried sausage up and washed it off. A stream of water flowed from her skeletal fingertip and over the sausage, cleaning the dirt off.

“How far did you have to walk to get to the Runner, Yvlon?”

“Four, five miles? She wouldn’t come any closer.”

“*Five miles?*”

Ceria ground her teeth. Yvlon only shrugged tiredly.

“Makes you wish Ryoka were in the area, doesn’t it?”

It did. City Runners were notorious for refusing to get near monsters or dangerous areas when delivering resupplies to adventurers—they were useful because they could save a day or more of travel, but they charged high prices and inconvenienced the adventurers who had to go and meet them.

“If I’d known you would have had to walk that far in the snow, I’d have sent Ksmvr with you.”

“Then the Runner would have just run away.”

Pisces unhelpfully interjected this as he stared at the bread and other food Ceria had purchased with their dwindling coin. The half-Elf scowled as she pulled out a block of cheese and stared at it.

“I told them half a block of cheese. Who’s taking down messages in that damn building?”

The custom for adventurers was to use the [Message] spell to send requests for gear, supplies, or even potions to the local Mage’s Guild or

similar buildings in cities. Depending on the urgency of the request (which naturally raised the price of the delivery exponentially), the guild would deliver the request to the local Runner's Guild where someone would hopefully fulfill it.

Really, it was a gamble sometimes. Prices were very high for deliveries, but most City Runners didn't like to take the risk of getting near a hotspot for monsters anyways. And when they did, they often waited far away from the actual requested delivery site, shining bullseye lanterns to let adventurers know they had to come out to pick up their package. And the *cost*—

“How much do we have left, Yvlon?”

“Do you want the good news or the bad news?”

“Good news.”

“We've got *one* gold coin left.”

Yvlon lifted up the empty money pouch and shook it. Even Pisces looked dismayed at that.

“That's *it*? How much did the Runner charge?”

“About average. But we didn't have that much to begin with, and this was the only way to get the food quickly.”

Ceria ground her teeth as she accepted the money pouch from Yvlon. That was the last of their coin, which meant their future was pretty straightforward.

“We've got food for two more days, then. If we can't find what we're looking for by then, it's over.”

Over. Ceria watched her three teammates react differently to the news.

Yvlon had the best reaction. She was a seasoned adventurer and a former Silver-rank team Captain. She just nodded, resigned to the outcome. She didn't like it clearly; her eyes were tight, but she knew that they had no other choice.

Ksmvr was interesting. He didn't even look that bothered by the news. He just nodded, and went back to studying the landscape. Didn't he care? Or did he put all his faith in her decisions? Either way, Ceria would have liked more emotion from him.

And less from Pisces. The young man's eyebrows snapped together furiously.

“Then what? We just give *up*?”

“If we have to. We don't have the coin to keep searching, Pisces.”

“Then what do we do, Springwalker? Do we go back and start taking other requests?”

“Maybe. If we have to. Unless you’ve got another idea?”

Pisces stared at her. He was grumpy, tired, and hungry. In short, he had the exact same mood as everyone else in the group. But he was also annoying, and he never hesitated to make his opinions clear.

“I don’t know if I would wish to continue my association with this group afterwards. I have as of late begun to question the merits of lending my services to this team.”

Yvlon frowned, probably trying to decode Pisces’ comment, and then out of genuine anger. Ceria didn’t rise to the bait. She just nodded.

“Fine. You want to quit? Do it after tomorrow.”

Pisces hesitated.

“Our searching would be much improved if you took *my* opinions.”

“We tried that. Didn’t work.”

Ceria pulled a knife out of its sheathe at her side. She began slicing the sausage into chunks and getting a meal ready. Ksmvr came over to help her as Pisces scowled and kept talking.

“One mistake hardly disqualifies my methods. We might have found the secret rooms by now if—”

“We didn’t. And we’ve checked a lot of damn places. Drop it, Pisces.”

“I came here under the assumption that we would find—”

“So did we all.”

Yvlon interrupted. She stared hard at Pisces. It was the first time in a while that Ceria remembered the other woman taking an active stance. But even her patience had limits. She glared at Pisces, but the other mage was hardly impressed.

“We all took a risk on this expedition, Pisces. If it fails, it’s no one’s fault. We just had bad luck.”

“Inefficiency, perhaps.”

“You think you could do better than a group of four?”

“If I had undead—”

Yvlon’s brows drew together. Ceria interrupted as she finished squishing some of the cheese into the hard shell of the bread with the sausage.

“If you did, the local Watch would have shot you full of arrows at Esthelm. And even if you got them here, those Shield Spiders would have

eaten your leg before your shambling zombies got close enough to pull you out of their nest.”

Ceria glared at Pisces. She was tired of his constant complaints. It hadn’t been bad at first; he hadn’t been annoyed until around day four. But then, it had been another burden to bear. But this last day he had been incessant.

The half-Elf and unhappy Captain of the Horns of Hammerad rubbed at her forehead, searching for a moderately diplomatic response.

“We’re all tired. We’re all frustrated. But only you keep complaining. Why don’t you keep quiet for a while, Pisces?”

Even Ksmvr nodded. He carefully handed the sandwich he’d made to Yvlon. The human woman hesitated, but accepted it reluctantly. She eyed the sandwich and paused for a good few seconds before biting it. Ceria saw Yvlon glance at Ksmvr, but the Antinium didn’t seem to notice.

“Ksmvr. Do you want another sandwich?”

“I will have just cheese on mine if that is acceptable.”

“Fine.”

The Antinium immediately loaded up his sandwich with a double-helping of cheese. Ceria, taking his example, added twice as much meat to hers instead of cheese. Ever since the Antinium had gotten past his allergy to gluten thanks to the magical charm, he’d been eating cheese sandwiches almost exclusively.

Pisces hadn’t made a sandwich yet. Ceria began assembling one, even though she privately would have rather made him do it. But then he might eat more than they could afford for the night, so she did it anyways. Pisces observed her working and commented with an acerbic tone as she was nearly done.

“Just so you know, I would never animate zombies to begin with. They are an inefficient use of mana, unless used as immediate shields. Ghouls or skeletons would be—”

“Dead *gods*, Pisces! Shut up! Just eat and we’ll talk about this tomorrow, alright?”

Her fragile temper snapped. Ceria hurled the sandwich she’d made at Pisces. He stopped the flying food in the air with a hand and an affronted look. But he did shut up.

The food was cold, somewhat hard to chew, and could have benefited from some time near the fire. But all four adventurers were so hungry that

they scarfed down the food in seconds. Ceria could have used a second helping, but she knew that was all they could afford to eat.

After that, they just sat around. Miserable. It really was miserable. Everyone stank a bit, but no one wanted to wash in this freezing weather. They were tired and uncomfortable, but at least they'd had something to eat.

It wasn't so much a spoken word, but sheer exhaustion that made all four begin grabbing their blankets. Ceria shivered even when she wrapped the cold, rough fabric around herself. She moved closer to the fire and saw that Yvlon and Pisces had done the same.

No one talked. Ksmvr neatly unpacked his blanket and then paused. He looked around at the other three, two humans and one half-Elf.

"It appeared that our preparations were decently sound. And our objective had much merit. Our approach was correct, and we have taken many optimal approaches. Yet we have thus far failed to achieve our goals. What went wrong?"

No one had an answer to that. They curled up in their blankets or in Ksmvr's case, sat with it draped around his body. It was a cold night.

The next day dawned cold and early. Ceria woke up shivering in her blankets. She should have used an ice resistance spell she reflected, but she needed to conserve mana. Plus...she'd never really studied those in Wistram. Irony, really.

Yvlon rolled out of her bedding at around the same time Ceria got up, and Ksmvr was already awake, if he'd ever slept. Only Pisces snoozed on, incredibly ignoring the cold weather, which suited the others just fine.

"Hot porridge. No spices, no fruits."

Yvlon handed Ceria a bowl. The half-Elf warmed her good hand as she held the food and shrugged.

"I've had worse. Want to look over the map as we eat?"

The young Human woman made an unhappy face.

"I guess so."

Ceria dreaded looking at the map too, to be honest. It was like staring at a piece of pie held just out of reach. Everything looked perfectly simple at first glance.

See the treasure? See the secret rooms? There's the treasure. But finding it—

“Okay, we tried digging around the ruined dome building yesterday, but there's nothing that even remotely resembles the other structures on the map. So we have to assume that area's lost or completely buried.”

Ceria pointed to a section of the map where a familiar dome-like structure was connected to what she could only see as a secret room. Yvlon nodded as she and Ksmvr stood around the map, staring hard at the places Ceria had marked.

“We have attempted numerous times to visit the second secret location in vain. It may be this section was also already claimed by previous searchers.”

Here was the problem: they had a map. And it was a good one; it showed Albez as it had been, a sprawling city complete with the secret passages and rooms that surely contained treasure. But the map did not reflect current reality.

The three Horns of Hammerad stood on a small bluff overlooking the ruins. Unlike the tidy map of the city, the ruins were, well, a mess.

Dead soil and dried-up vegetation was the landscape that made up Albez's tomb. But the city itself had not fallen to magic or sword as far as Ceria could tell. It had simply...disappeared into the earth.

Maybe a mudslide had covered it. Or an earthquake had engulfed the city. But it had sunk below the earth, becoming covered by time and dirt until some expedition had uncovered it. Since then, the entire area had turned into a basin filled with half-buried walls and lovely pitfalls that connected a subterranean landscape with the rest of the world. And after all these many hundreds, thousands of years, everything had changed.

Parts of the ruins had shifted in the earth, somehow. Entire passages had moved out of place, and some of the buildings on Ceria's map were in the wrong places. Worse, some were in the right place as far as she could tell, which made searching even more confusing.

“We know the passage here leads to a secret room. But if we follow it, we get nothing. Just rubble and dirt. We might be able to find the room if we had a team of [Diggers] and [Miners], but we don't.”

Ceria crossed out another potential treasure site with a bit of charcoal on the map. She eyed the remaining spots they'd pinpointed nearly a week ago. Honestly, it felt like a lifetime. All that hope they'd had quickly

dissipated as they'd gone from spot to spot, digging in the crumbling soil for traces of something they'd never found.

Yvlon squinted at a ragged piece of blue cloth tied to a wooden pole. She pointed.

"We found that marker right around the room marked here. See? I think someone must have claimed that spot."

That was probably true. Ceria nodded glumly. Searchers often marked their finds with flags or magical signs only they could read in case they'd stumbled onto part of a larger haul.

Ksmvr looked confused. At least, Ceria assumed he was confused. He certainly sounded like it.

"How would someone locate a secret room without a map such as this? Or have other groups obtained similar information sources?"

"Not necessarily. They might have had a [Treasure Hunter]. It's a rare class, but a high-level one might have had a skill that located a major haul."

"Are we to assume all the places here have been looted, then?"

Both Ceria and Yvlon shook their heads instantly. If that was the case, they wouldn't have risked so much on this.

"Even someone with Skills can't find everything. Especially if the places are guarded. We've just been unlucky, or hitting places already searched. We need to go somewhere else today."

"How about over here? There's several rooms that belonged to some sort of complex. And a passage here and here...worth a shot?"

Studying the places Yvlon had pointed to, Ceria had to agree that it looked like there was a secret passage over there as well. She nodded.

"I think that spot matches that depression over to the east, don't you? We'll head for that after Pisces wakes up, then."

It took a few kicks for the mage to wake up. He was grumpy when he found only a bit of porridge was left for his breakfast, and even unhappier when he found they'd decided on the next place to search without him.

"I thought adventurers considered all opinions and made informed decisions, rather than rashly coming to conclusion without all input."

"We'd do that if you woke up earlier. If you've got a more likely spot to search, find it."

He couldn't, which only made Pisces more grumpy. The Horns of Hammerad struck camp and began cautiously picking their way across the snowy ground towards the ruins, letting Ksmvr take point.

Even as they were moving across the ruins, the group moved slowly, keeping an eye out for anything moving in the snow or strange sounds. Monsters were common around magical sites and the ruins were a known dangerous spot.

However, aside from a nasty run in with a small nest of Shield Spiders, the Horns of Hammerad hadn't run into many monsters. That bothered Ceria. She didn't like *not* having trouble, especially here.

The Horns of Hammerad under Calruz had gone on four different occasions into Albez, looking for treasure like all of the other Silver-rank teams in the area. It was practically a rite of passage; if you could survive Albez, you were ready for harder requests.

But even during the easiest time they'd had here in the past – running into a Mothbear and then a group of Yellow Shamblers – Ceria couldn't ever remember the ruins feeling this...empty.

She cleared her throat as Ksmvr stopped on top of a slanted block of stone and scanned the area, shortbow in hands. He looked over at her and Yvlon and Pisces stopped to listen.

"Keep your eyes peeled for monsters. We don't want anything creeping up on us."

It probably didn't need to be said again. Pisces certainly snorted and kept walking. But Yvlon and Ksmvr nodded and moved forwards with even more vigilance.

And then they were at the designated search site. Ceria stared down into a collapsed room and tried to compare the dimensions of the rubble to one of the rooms on the map. It was...a rough fit.

"Looks like we should be able to hit another room if we move a few paces up. See?"

The others crowded around the map, trying to find a good point to break into the supposed secret tunnel. It was supposed to lead out of one of the rooms—residential chambers by the looks of them—into another, larger room. It looked exactly like a secret room, in short, but finding that exact spot would be difficult.

By now of course, the four knew what to do. Yvlon and Ksmvr both grabbed a shovel and chose spots apart from each other before they dug down, hoping to hit a stone roof or other part of the building.

Ceria watched them work, keeping an eye out for danger. Part of her optimistic. The other half—

“We will not find anything this way.”

She looked over to her left. Pisces stood with her, staring at Yvlon and Ksmvr with a disgusted expression on his face. On the first day they’d all taken turns digging until their fingers were blistered. Now the stronger two dug until they thought they’d found something, in which case Pisces and Ceria would pitch in.

“You do realize how deep the secret rooms could be?”

“I know. Normally we’d have hired a digging team, we’d have twice as many adventurers and maybe even joined another team. But we don’t have the time for that—and any other group would demand equal shares of the treasure, maybe even try to take it all. And...neither Yvlon nor I have the credibility to persuade anyone to join us, anyways.”

Ceria grimaced. They’d encountered a...bad reception in Esthelm. The other adventurers they’d met had either had words of sympathy or outright contempt and anger for her, but especially Yvlon. All the local adventurers had known someone who’d died in the crypt.

“So instead we have two inexperienced hands and two mages not specialized in earth magic? Hardly better.”

For once, she couldn’t refute his statement. Ceria grimaced.

“We went haring off without a plan. We should have prepared more, planned for this.”

It was the excitement of finding the map. It had overtaken their good sense and made even Ceria and Yvlon ignore their instincts which told them they should have prepared for at least a month and had three times as much coin as they’d borrowed from Erin. But they’d hoped.

Pisces nodded dourly. He had a fresh porridge stain on the neck of his robe.

“I blame myself.”

“Oh, do you really?”

“I should have predicted this outcome. And insisted we use my creations to expedite the process.”

“Pisces. We’ve talked about this.”

“We have. But you have not listened properly as of yet.”

Ceria sighed. She’d gone several rounds with Pisces before, but this time he looked like he had dug his heels in. He was practically impossible to budge in this state.

“You know how Yvlon and I feel about the undead.”

“I know.”

“Summoning the dead is a crime up north unless you have an agreement with the local cities—which you don’t.”

“All true.”

“Well?”

“Without my undead, we will never dig down deep enough. All we will do is unearth previously found structures like we have all week. You need a tireless workforce; I have the means to create one. All that is getting in the way is your distaste.”

It was a rational argument, delivered in a calm, cool voice. It was so like the old Pisces that Ceria had to glance sideways at him.

Yes. If you looked past the dirty hair and clothing, there were traces of the young man she’d known. Still traces. She wavered.

“Still.”

“Springwalker, I can sense the bodies below us. There’s enough for me to animate several skeletons at least. Probably quite a bit more if need be.”

Pisces looked Ceria in the eye like he used to. His eyes were focused on hers, and he had that old intensity, the old half-manic stare of utter determination in his eyes.

“What is more important, Ceria? Your pride or success here?”

That settled it. Ceria closed her eyes and raised her voice.

“Yvlon!”

When the other adventurer came over Ceria explained Pisces’ point in curt words. Yvlon’s face closed off and she looked at Pisces. He returned the gaze steadily.

“Pisces has a point. We kept unearthing emptied ruins. We might have to go deep and we’re out of time. His undead might be our only shot. What do you think?”

The golden-haired warrior looked unhappy. She hadn’t been overtly hostile towards Pisces on the journey, but then, she hadn’t let him summon any undead either. She pushed some of her dirty hair out of the way.

“You are the Captain, Ceria. If you think it’s worth a shot, I’ll put up with it.”

Her tone and stance made it clear that she did *not* want Ceria to say yes. But Ceria had already made up her mind.

“Okay, Pisces. Do it.”

Pisces nodded. He stood up and raised his hands. He made no audible gestures, and didn't showboat. But Ceria sensed his mana gathering and probing down below. She shuddered, knowing what he was looking for.

"Ceria? Is he doing anything...wrong?"

Yvlon's voice was quiet, but her eyes were intent on the half-Elf's face. Ceria knew how Yvlon had to feel—it wasn't like either of them had liked undead before the ruins. And now...

"Nothing wrong, at least magically."

"And you're sure this is the only way?"

"The best we have. I don't like it either. You know that. But it's his main class, Yvlon. He's a good mage, but he was always best at his passions. As a [Necromancer], he's powerful. Let him do this once."

The former Captain's lips twisted, but she clearly didn't want to dispute Ceria's decision in public. She shook her head and planted the shovel in the dirt.

"I'll stand watch with Ksmvr. If he's pulling up the dead, we might as well let them work."

Ceria nodded gratefully, watching as Yvlon picked her way over to Ksmvr. After a few seconds of discussion they walked off to keep a lookout, leaving her with Pisces.

"Rise. Rise from the place where you rest to do my bidding. Claw through stone and dirt to where I stand and obey my orders..."

He was speaking to the earth, his voice lower and audibly infused with the echoing tones of someone casting magic. Ceria shook her head as she sensed the magic leaving him and entering the earth.

"Is that necessary? Can't you just cast [Raise Dead] and have done with it?"

Pisces shuddered and blinked as he came out of the trance he'd entered to cast the spell. Ceria caught him before he overbalanced and let go immediately. He blinked at her and then nodded once.

It was so...hard sometimes to act normal around him. At least this time Pisces didn't sniff obnoxiously.

"It's not that simple when you don't stick to set spells. You should know that, Ceria. I told you, if you cast a spell the same way each time, you don't learn anything."

"Fine. So you improvised. I assume you cast multiple raise dead spells at range?"

“[Raise Skeleton], in point of fact. They are the most cost-effective, or so I’ve found.”

“Oh good.”

Pisces pointed at an area of ground ahead of them.

“There is a considerable group of dead bodies below us. That might indicate a secret room is indeed down there.”

“It might mean it’s already been looted.”

“Perhaps. Or that it was found but never successfully entered. Either way, I have summoned several skeletons that will assist with the digging.”

Ceria stared at the ground. She didn’t see the normal tremors of dirt or hands clawing their way out of the soil that preceded a zombie bursting out to try and eat her face off.

“Something taking them a while? Or did you just tell them to take it easy?”

Pisces scowled at the needling, and Ceria immediately regretted the words. It had been a powerful spell; she could see him sweating a bit in the cold.

“They must find their way up from a considerable distance. A shame you couldn’t remember where the Lich was, Springwalker.”

“You can’t animate a Lich, Pisces.”

“Maybe not from scratch. But if I had the bones of one—”

“You could animate it? Really?”

“Perhaps. I should like to study the spell animating it at least.”

The half-Elf eyed her once friend as he mumbled to himself. He thought he could create a Lich? Or learn the spell to make one?

That was...concerning. A Lich wasn’t the highest-level undead; not by far. But it was powerful. Powerful enough that if Pisces could animate one by himself, he was stronger than Ceria had given him credit for.

“What level *are* you by now? In your [Necromancer] class, I mean.”

The mage stopped muttering to himself. He turned to stare flatly at Ceria.

“What do you care? Didn’t you tell me last time we parted ways that you never wanted to hear from me again?”

“That was then. Somehow we’ve ended up working together again.”

“Yes. I suppose I should thank Erin Solstice for that.”

“Maybe you should. Or will you curse her for it?”

“I had no objections to working with you, Springwalker. But you were the one who told me you didn’t want to travel with me.”

“Yeah. I did.”

Ceria dearly wished she used a staff like Sostrom used to carry around. True, it was cumbersome, but it would have been so nice to lean on. She contented herself with sitting on a rock.

“I haven’t exactly changed my opinion of necromancy since then. You do know that the undead killed my team, and Yvlon’s? I saw a lot of friends die thanks to them.”

Pisces just shook his head.

“The undead are mindless. Or rather, most are. The ones under my command are not the same as those roving creatures.”

“Some would say there’s not a lot of difference. If you lose control or get killed, they’re still mindless.”

“Only if I don’t realize my goals.”

“Still going on about that? I’d have thought you gave up by now. You certainly don’t seem to have made much progress.”

To her surprise, Pisces grinned rather than grow defensive at her jibe. That made her cautious. But he glanced over at the ground and she heard the sounds of dirt scattering. The first of the skeletons was digging itself out of the ground.

“Oh good. The diggers are here. Get them to work, will you?”

Both Yvlon and Ksmvr watched from their posts as five more skeletons dug themselves out to join the one Pisces had summoned. Two grabbed shovels; the others just got to digging in the earth with their bare hands.

Yvlon turned away as the skeletons with glowing eyes started working. Ksmvr just watched with interest. Ceria took a seat on a rock next to Pisces as they chatted in the cold.

“It seems odd that Ksmvr wouldn’t be a better digger.”

“He was not built for it, Springwalker. He may share the same body, but he clearly lacks the experience.”

“All things to their intended purpose, eh? Surprised to hear *you* of all people say that.”

“I am not suggesting it is effective. I am simply stating what is. Do not misconstrue my words.”

“...Sorry.”

They sat in silence for a while, watching as the skeletons got to work. They moved with commendable speed in the cold, and despite being weaker than Ksmvr and Yvlon, they were tireless. Ceria already wondered why they hadn't used them earlier, until she remembered exactly why.

"They look like they'll get a good way down before the day's over. Maybe this will work."

"One can only hope."

Pisces grunted as he stared at his creations. His stomach growled audibly in the wind. As if in answer, Ceria's did likewise.

"Isn't it funny? A few years ago we'd be in the banquet hall, stuffing our faces over a book of spells."

"True."

"...Do you miss it?"

"Of course."

His voice was soft. Pisces stared at his undead, remembering just like she was.

"But it is the past. I gave it up for my passions. There is no use looking back."

"To you, maybe. I wonder what would have happened if—you were a better mage once, when you didn't practice Necromancy."

The words were still bitter and from a dark place inside Ceria. But she couldn't help them coming out. This time Pisces didn't snap at her. He just shrugged tiredly.

"Some thought so. But I was a generalist then; a jack of no masteries. Necromancy was ever my passion. I might have had the dregs of popular support, but only that. Who would applaud a mage without a master or a calling?"

"I respected you. So did Mons and a lot of other people."

"Ah."

There wasn't anything he could say to that. Pisces stared at the flying dirt and two skeletons trying to lift a large stone out of a hole they'd dug.

"Mons. Yes. What happened to her? I didn't hear of another mage joining you when you left Wistram. Did she...?"

"She kept studying in Wistram. Who knows? By now she might be a better [Mage] than you or I."

"Hah. Perhaps. She certainly knows more spells by now at least."

They both laughed at that. Then they grew silent. Ceria could sense what was coming, but her tongue kept leading her onwards.

“You know, even if you had become a [Necromancer], it might have all been okay if you hadn’t...”

“I told you, it was to a purpose.”

“But you didn’t even ask permission.”

“I didn’t need it. Cognita said as much. The rules they made—”

“It’s the principle of the thing, Pisces. You spat in their faces and said —”

The other mage cut her off. His face was tight and drawn, and Ceria knew he was reliving the same moment, just like her.

“I...erred. But I did what I thought was best. It is the past, now. Continuing the same argument would be pointless. You fail to understand my position as you have in the past.”

“I guess so. But you have to admit, it didn’t end like you’d hoped.”

“No. It didn’t. I realize that now.”

It was the first time she’d ever heard him admit he’d been wrong. Ceria looked at Pisces in surprise.

“You do?”

Shrug.

“Recent events have given me cause to...regret the ending. That is all.”

“Yeah. Yeah. Neither of us are exactly earning Wistram rates, are we?”

“No. But I was astounded to receive a message from you. I didn’t even know you were still on the same continent. What made you decide to come here?”

“I came to Izril to earn money. To become a better adventurer, since I couldn’t stay in Wistram.”

“Why not Baleros or Chandrar?”

“Too far and too violent. For both, really. I didn’t want to join a Company; I wanted to make my own choices.”

“Hmm.”

Ceria looked sideways at Pisces.

“What about you? Why did you decide to become an adventurer? Didn’t you swear to me you’d pursue your own path?”

“I...need to be a higher level. That’s all.”

“Really? But you won’t level up that much from just casting mage spells.”

“True. But...well, perhaps I’m also looking for something else.”

“What?”

“One last chance.”

“For what?”

He hesitated. Pisces stared at the ground, as the cold wind blew his robes around him.

“To—”

Below them in the ditch they’d hollowed out, one of the skeletons raised its shovel and brought it down on a section of ground. The earth around it collapsed, and the undead disappeared.

The earth rumbled as dirt and stone shifted. Instantly, Ceria and Pisces stepped back, feeling the ground under their feet *shift* slightly.

“*Collapse!* Get clear!”

Ceria shouted to Yvlon and Ksmvr as the tremors grew. She stumbled back, looking for safe ground, grabbing Pisces as he tripped after her.

Collapses were a big danger in older dungeons and in places like this. It was all too possible to be swallowed by the earth. Ceria saw Yvlon and Ksmvr running to a large section of stone, hoping to find a safe place on the solid rock. She tried to run after them.

And then, as soon as the horrible rumbling had started, it stopped. Ceria turned shakily and found Pisces getting to his feet. He brushed dirt off of his robes and then turned to stare as well.

“Tree rot. Look at that.”

A huge gaping sinkhole had opened up where the skeletons had been. Ceria could spot two climbing up, but not the other four.

“Trap spell! Get down!”

Pisces shouted it and Ceria immediately dove back into the soil. She saw Yvlon and Ksmvr who’d been running over to them do the same. She turned to look and saw what had alarmed Pisces.

Giant ribbons of flame that writhed and twisted around like snakes were burning around the fallen dirt and stone. The flames weren’t red and orange; these were *blue*, and already they were melting stone and turning the dirt into smoke that began to billow up from the hole.

“Pisces. Is it aimed at—?”

“No. Let me see.”

The other mage raised his face out of the dirt and focused. Two of his skeletons approached the pit.

“I’ve lost three of my skeletons. Two were incinerated; the other crushed. Last one’s trapped under some dirt. The other two aren’t being targeted—looks like we set off an area trap.”

“Thank flowers for that.”

Ceria sighed and let some of the tension ease out of her body. She’d hoped for something to happen, but she hadn’t expected *that*.

“We just dug straight into that secret corridor, didn’t we? And by the looks of it, it leads to a [Mage]’s quarters.”

“Looks like it.”

For a second the two mages stared down at the dancing flames. Ceria was already trying to analyze the spell; the amount of mana she could sense in the flames and the way they were instantly burning through the huge amount of stone and dirt in the way told her that it was a seriously powerful spell they’d tripped down there. What Tier? Tier 5? 6?

“Ceria! Pisces! Are you two alright?”

Yvlon’s voice echoed and Ceria realized she and Ksmvr probably couldn’t see what she did. She scrambled to her feet and waved her hand at the two prone forms that were slowly crawling towards them.

“It’s fine! The skeletons broke through the roof of a new area! The falling stones must have set off some of the magical protections. Stay clear, everyone!”

Yvlon and Ksmvr got to their feet. They made their way over to Pisces and Ceria as the two tried to dust themselves off.

“We just heard the rumbling when the earth began to collapse. Good thing we weren’t standing closer.”

“Indeed. That would have most likely resulted in our painful immolation.”

Both humans and the half-Elf fell silent as they stared at Ksmvr. He stared back.

“Unless Pisces or Ceria know powerful anti-flame spells?”

“No.”

“Nope.”

“You’re probably right, Ksmvr. Thank you for sharing that.”

All four adventurers turned their attention back to the pit. Yvlon whistled.

“Those flames are still going? That must be some trap spell. Who were they expecting to kill? Named Adventurers?”

“Ah. It—”

“It’s probably—”

Ceria and Pisces broke off. Both of them had spoken at once. They shared a look and then Ceria explained.

“We hit the binding matrix of the spell. That’s why it’s still going. All the mana is being depleted and it’s not going to recharge after it’s over.”

“Oh. I see.”

Ksmvr looked down into the pit.

“May I ask what the nature of this spell is? It appears to be mainly aimed at close-range magic. Is there any unusual component to it?”

That was what Ceria had been trying to figure out. She rubbed at her chin.

“I’m not sure. That’s some kind of pyromancy trap for sure. But blue flames? It looks like a variation of that [Flame Snake] spell we read about, remember?”

Pisces nodded absently.

“An upgraded version. Clearly evident from the blue flames and extreme heat.”

“Clearly. Probably be practically impossible to block if it suddenly came at us.”

“Indeed. The walls were probably reinforced to avoid sudden escape. Would a trap wall have blocked any retreat?”

“Maybe...”

Yvlon looked at the two mages.

“What’s the verdict?”

Ceria nodded.

“Good. That’s a powerful spell. And it was fresh. No one’s triggered it before or we’d see the scorch marks. There’s a good chance no one’s explored this place before. And best yet—”

“What they’re guarding could be just as valuable.”

Pisces smiled, and so did Yvlon. Ksmvr just moved his jaws slightly.

“This is good, correct? Should we descend once the flames have ceased?”

“Definitely. Get ready everyone! We’re going in!”

Suddenly energized, Ceria began calling more mana into her skeletal hand as she reviewed spells. Yvlon put on a helmet and began swinging her

sword lightly. Ksmvr armed himself with the shortsword and knife for close-quarters combat. Pisces recalled his two skeletons.

The mood of the group had completely changed in a few seconds. The pressure of imminent death—but more importantly, the thought that they might have found something truly important—had given them the same burning hope they'd had at the beginning. Ceria could barely contain her eagerness as they waited for the spell to end.

“Don't go in for at least thirty minutes after the fires have stopped. The heat down there is intense.”

Indeed, the smoking stones were radiating an intense heat that completely ignored the cold air. Ceria was already starting to warm up even far as she was from the sinkhole. Pisces stared down at the entrance to the tunnel, barely able to conceal his excitement.

“I could cast [Frozen Wind] to expedite the cooling process.”

“Save your mana. We don't know what's down there. In fact—let's get started on the trap dummy. I was going to use the mud ball method, but why not one of your skeletons.”

“Right. Let's.”

Even Yvlon didn't object as Ceria and Pisces got to work on one of the skeletons. Only Ksmvr was confused. He stared at the two mages as they started handing the skeleton items and muttering about enchantments.

“Excuse me. What is happening?”

Ceria paused as she handed the skeleton a hefty rock to hold. Pisces was busy with a torch he was trying to light.

“Oh. You've never seen adventurers entering a trapped dungeon, have you, Ksmvr?”

“No. What is the purpose of equipping the skeleton thusly?”

This time it was Yvlon who explained. She gestured at the skeleton as Ceria cast an enchantment over it. A ball of light hovered around the skeleton's head, radiating light that added to the flame of the torch in its other hand.

“When we go into dungeons, we're always wary of traps. They claim more lives than monsters most of the time. If we had a [Rogue] or [Scout] we could rely on their trap-sensing Skills but we don't have one. And even then, it's extremely risky for anyone who goes in first. Most of the adventurers who take point—don't survive.”

Ceria nodded grimly. She'd buried more friends than she cared to remember who'd gone in and received the business end of a trap or monster's claw. Yvlon had the same expression as she continued.

"So. We find ways to trigger traps beforehand. One common way is to shoot an arrow at an obvious tripwire or pressure plate, but a lot of traps are magical. So adventurers will roll something down a suspicious corridor—we use mud balls if we can't use anything else. But a lot of traps have more sophisticated sensors."

"Hence using the undead. They might not trip detection for living beings, but by giving them a heat source and the weight of a normal adventurer, this one will probably trigger most traps. And the magical enchantment also activates a lot of sensors."

Pisces explained as he made the skeleton walk towards the edge of the unearthed corridor. Ceria nodded.

"Hopefully we're not dealing with an experienced trap maker. If this is a mage's personal quarters—well, they're pretty bad at differentiating the activation mechanism for spells. We might get all the traps this way."

"Excuse me. I am confused once again. I thought this was a dungeon. What was this about a personal mage's quarters?"

"It's...hard to explain, Ksmvr. We say 'dungeon', but that doesn't mean this place was originally built underground. I think Albez was actually a city that sunk into the ground over thousands of years."

"Oh. I see."

The Antinium considered this.

"So we are, in fact, likely breaking into a deceased individual's personal quarters?"

Ceria, Pisces, and Yvlon looked at each other.

"Pretty much."

"Hopefully."

"Or a treasury owned by a guild or rich person. Those are always nice."

"Then why all the traps? The spell we just witnessed seemed excessive?"

Ceria shrugged.

"Paranoia. It's usually because people have something important they don't want stolen. And a powerful mage around Level 50? They'd have a lot of enemies, a lot of artifacts and valuables over the years. Their homes tend to turn into miniature gauntlets by the time they die."

Yvlon nodded.

“In some cases, the protections are justified. Consider what powerful items a mage might own? On the other hand, artificial dungeons—ones that people make for the exclusive purpose of guarding something really rare—are the worst. This is more like a few private wards on a home. But dungeons designed to kill a huge number of invaders? Those are real deathtraps.”

“Indeed? How so?”

Ksmvr barely had to get the others started. Even Pisces had stories of the horrors adventurers had found in ruins.

“I heard in one dungeon the creators placed an invisible poison mist trap at the entrance. So while the adventurers were clearing the dungeon they were slowly dying. Hundreds of teams would go in without problems, but none ever came out.”

“What about the acid showers? Did you hear about that? It triggered five hundred meters in and flooded each corridor. If it didn’t have such a long reset time it would have wiped every team that went in there.”

“I heard of one mage who just teleported the people in the trap into a pit in the middle of bedrock. They had no way out and they’d just starve to death.”

“I heard of that one too! The [Miners] who eventually located the trap—didn’t they find some adventurers still alive in there? They’d eaten all their friends and were living off their boots.”

“That’s just a myth. No one would have the air to survive down there.”

“I heard they had a charm.”

“True, but even so—”

Bemused, Ksmvr glanced around at the others.

“You seem unusually upbeat for such a dire circumstance we might be facing ourselves.”

“That’s part of what being an adventurer is, Ksmvr. We risk everything, so we might as well chuckle a bit in case the worst does come true.”

Ceria laughed. Even Yvlon grinned at the Antinium.

“We’re building morale before we enter. Don’t worry—we’re all nervous. But it’s better to tell jokes than to wait in silence.”

Ksmvr considered this, and then nodded.

“I shall learn from this experience. Thank you for explaining it to me.”

That was weird, but it just made the others laugh harder. Because it was weird and they were about to enter a place where they might die. Soon, Ceria judged the hole to be cool enough to enter, and after sending the skeleton in first, the others slid down the melted rock and entered the abandoned tunnel.

“Okay, that was a nasty arrow trap. Pisces, you’re walking in front from now on.”

Ceria eyed the deadly poison-tipped bolt that had neatly passed through the skeleton’s ribs and shattered on the far wall. She didn’t even want to touch the arrow in case all of it was toxic.

Pisces shook his head. He pointed and the skeleton obediently trotted forwards again.

“I will stay behind the two warriors, thank you. They have armor. I do not.”

“You have that ring. It probably would have saved your life.”

Ceria watched as the skeleton advanced fifteen more paces into the darkness and rounded a bend. The tunnel they’d found was long and winding and this was the second trap they’d run into. The first one had been an easily-triggered trap that had unleashed the dreaded spray of acid when Ksmvr had fired an arrow at it. The second the skeleton had triggered and Ceria was only concerned there might be more.

Several hours had passed since the Horns of Hammerad had entered the tunnel. Despite that, they’d gone less than eighty paces. This was due to the excruciating care all four were taking to check for traps every inch of the way.

All of them had long sticks they used to poke at the wall, ceiling, and floor, and Pisces regularly sent his other two skeletons ahead to stomp or bang on walls in hopes of triggering something. Even when they thought it was safe, the Horns of Hammerad went in a line, one at a time, letting Ksmvr or Yvlon go forwards a good ways before the others cautiously caught up.

“The tunnel can’t be that much longer. The map shows it leading to a good-sized space ahead, right?”

Ceria didn’t even have to look at the map in her pack. She nodded.

“That’s right. Hopefully we get there by tonight. Otherwise...we could set up camp there.”

Again, it was Yvlon who had the calm acceptance of this fact; she’d probably expected that to begin with, and Ksmvr who deferred instantly to her leadership. But Pisces scowled.

“Camp *here*? But this corridor is wide open! We should endeavor to get to the end before nightfall—I don’t want a monster cornering us in here.”

“Better that than rushing, Pisces.”

The scowl Ceria gave Pisces was returned with equal value. She hated how he balked at every decision she made. She knew he was eager—she remembered the same feeling and even the same conversation. But she’d seen what happened when they rushed.

Pisces *clicked* his teeth together as Ceria replied.

“We don’t risk anything. Even if it means two days—even if we had to leave this place and come back with supplies rather than risk going in without moving safely, I’d do it. As it is, we’re still way too close to the trap radius if we hit something large. We’re risking a lot as it is, Pisces. I won’t just walk us into death.”

He clicked his teeth together a few more times, clearly upset. But then Pisces sighed.

“Very well. I defer to your experience.”

That surprised Ceria; she’d been sure he would have fought her more on this.

“Really? Good.”

“Yes, well—”

Pisces paused and *clicked* his teeth again. This time Yvlon scowled at him.

“Would you stop doing that? It’s distracting?”

“Me? I’m not doing that. I thought Ksmvr—”

They all looked at the Antinium. He whirled. His mandibles opened as the *clicking* suddenly grew louder and they all realized it wasn’t coming from them.

“*Attack!*”

Something hurtled out of the darkness and knocked the trap-finding skeleton to the ground. Ceria caught a glimpse of whirling scythe-like legs, biting mandibles and pinchers, as she pointed.

“[Ice Spike]!”

She fired the spell at the same time Pisces threw a ball of fire. The spells did not comedically connect and miss—first Ceria’s ice spike blasted into the creature, hurling it backwards, and then Pisces’ flaming ball of magic struck the skeleton. The splatter of flames didn’t touch the creature, but it did illuminate it.

Ceria saw long, almost spider-like legs coated in armor, and a squat, elongated form. But this was no shield-spider. It had too many legs, and barbs on those legs. And it was...dripping. The red and purple carapace and exposed internal organs *shifted* as the creature opened a maw with rows of circular teeth. It *crunched* the piece of skeleton it had bit off as more emerged from the darkness.

“Aw hell! *Crelers!*”

Ceria screamed the words as she pointed at more Crelers. The small creatures scuttled around the corridor, leaping for the adventurers, trying to claw, bite, *dig* their way through their enemies.

“Cover me!”

Yvlon rushed forwards, sword slicing down at the lead Creler. Her blade battered the creature down, but even her sharp steel could only cut through the exposed organs of the creature. The rest—hard chitin and other bone-like substances—was too strong and the creature tried to scuttle up Yvlon’s leg.

“Perish.”

Ksmvr used his three arms as the other two Crelers came towards him. He grabbed one, ignoring the sharp edges that tore into his hand and began slicing with the other two weapons in his possession. Like Yvlon he couldn’t immediately cut the creature in two, but he had the leverage to slowly pierce the creature’s body with his blades as he sawed at it.

The other Creler tried to jump onto Ksmvr’s back, but Ceria blasted it off with a precise spell. She covered the other two, launching rapid [Ice Spikes] that, despite throwing the Crelers back, failed to inflict crucial damage.

“Springwalker! Behind!”

Ceria dove out of the way. Pisces raised his hand, and a gust of icy air froze the Creler that had leapt at him. It fell to the ground, stunned, and a skeleton rushed over. It began to stomp.

All three skeletons were fighting, Ceria saw. They’d grabbed stones and were trying to crush the Crelers to death. But they were almost all blades

and sharp edges. You had to have a mace—Calruz had killed most of them himself with his axe!

“Freeze them, Ceria!”

She heard Pisces yell, but then a Creler was jumping at her face. Ceria jerked backwards, and the razor-mouth stopped a foot in front of her face as she seized it with her skeletal hand. Instantly, the Creler tried to bite through her bone and Ceria reacted.

“Die, damn you!”

It wasn't so much a spell as concentrated ice magic. Instantly, the air around her hand *froze* and Ceria felt the extreme cold as her skeletal hand froze the Creler in her grasp. It *screeched* and writhed, but she refused to let go. The monstrosity's legs and claws waved about, threatening to score her flesh even as she held it as far away as possible. But after five seconds it stiffened up and died, frozen to death in her grasp.

Shaking, Ceria let go. But she didn't have time to wait. She spun and began blasting the Crelers trying to swarm Yvlon's armor. The other woman took the impacts as [Ice Spikes] deflected off her armor—she hurled a Creler to the ground and stepped on it to an accompanying shriek.

Ceria ran forwards and blasted a Creler with an [Ice Spike] dead on. This time the force of the impact *broke* the creature; it collapsed, several legs breaking off its body as yellow slime exited the wounds. Ceria shuddered and spun, searching for another target.

In another second it was over. Pisces threw fire onto the last Creler being held down by his skeletons and Ksmvr finished smashing the second one with his enchanted iron blade. The Crelers twitched and made bubbling sounds where they lay, but they were too far dead to move.

Ceria stumbled backwards, gasping as sweat poured down her face and the exertion of using so much magic caught up with her. She grabbed onto Yvlon and the other woman stumbled.

“Yvlon. Did they get you?”

The golden-haired Captain was also gasping for air, but she shook her head.

“They didn't get into my head. Think some cut into my breastplate, but didn't get my skin.”

“Sorry about the [Ice Spikes]. Did I hurt you or pierce your armor?”

“A few dents. I'm okay. Thanks.”

Ceria nodded. She could have pierced Yvlon's armor and killed her if the [Ice Spike] spells had been at closer range or hit a weak joint. But better that than let a Creler at Yvlon's exposed head. It would have chewed its way into her armor through the stump of her neck in a second.

"Well, that explains why we haven't run into more monsters or undead recently. Crelers."

"Dead gods."

The two women looked over at Ksmvr and Pisces. Pisces was unharmed, if pale and shaken, but Ksmvr had been wounded. They went over to look.

"It is nothing. My hand is lacerated in several places, but Pisces has bound the injuries. It will heal."

"Are you sure?"

Ceria peered at the already green-stained bandage Pisces had wound around Ksmvr's hand. The Antinium nodded.

"I am fine."

"Crelers have toxins in their bites and claws—"

"It will not affect me. Thank you for the concern."

"Dead gods, Ksmvr! I've never seen anyone *hold* a Creler down to kill it! Are you insane?"

"I just fought as the Antinium do against them. I am relieved they were only small."

"Yeah. Yeah. Pisces, you alright?"

"I—I hate those things."

Pisces shuddered as he stared at a twitching Creler. Ceria nodded. So did Yvlon. And Ksmvr.

"Dead gods. Crelers. Just imagine if there had been a few more—"

"Those skeletons saved us. The Crelers went for us, but they held them away. Got chewed up. Look at that one—"

"Shh. Shh. Are there any more around?"

At once everyone fell silent. Ceria listened to her racing heartbeat, but Ksmvr shook his head.

"This group we awakened, but there are no more nearby. But the evidence is clear; there is a nest nearby."

He indicated the dying Crelers on the ground. A skeleton had seized a rock and was industriously smashing each one to bits.

“These are in their first stage of life. If an adult Creler were in our proximity it would already have attacked. I recommend immediate extermination.”

“Exterminate? A nest?”

Pisces looked at Ksmvr in horror, but the Antinium only nodded. He was deadily focused.

“They are a threat. A menace. If they remain here unchecked, some will grow to adult size. That cannot be allowed to happen.”

Ceria completely agreed, but she didn’t want to be the one to hunt Crelers.

“Normally we get a bounty for reporting them in. Hunting a nest—plague fungus, I don’t want to think about that, Ksmvr. There’s a big bounty on them, true, but—”

“I believe there will not be more than this number. And they would be in their larval form rather than their attack form.”

Yvlon cleaned her blade, staring at a Creler claw that kept twitching.

“Might be doable, Ceria. One good thrust kills them if they’re in their larvae form. We take them by surprise—”

“No! Have you seen what they can do to flesh?”

Pisces was pale, shaking. Ceria looked at him, and then Ksmvr.

“I think Ksmvr’s right, Pisces.”

“What?”

“Do *you* want a bunch of Crelers at our back if they get hungry or wake up? If we keep going they might hit our backs at the worst moment. We’ve gotta take them out.”

“I—fine. Fine. But the skeletons go first!”

Their group moved on. It took only a few seconds for them to round the corridor and spot the part of the wall that had been tunneled out for Crelers to climb out of. It was a big hole that lead to another naturally forming bubble in the earth. And there they found....

“Dead gods.”

Yvlon whispered it as the four adventurers and three skeletons crept into the heart of a Creler nest. In fairness, it was a tiny one, but Ceria spotted no less than eight Crelers in their larval, incubating stage.

When they weren’t all exposed organs and vicious, lacerating limbs and teeth, Crelers looked like horrible, fat, red caterpillars glowing faintly from within. Inside their semi-translucent ‘skins’, Ceria could see yellow lines

and discolored organs moving around within. They were growing. Just as Ksmvr said, if they were allowed a few months and food, they might turn into adults, the nightmares even Gold-rank teams didn't want to fight.

One of the Crelers was on the wall nearest to Ceria. She edged further into the nest, trying not to move or even breathe. Yvlon tiptoed forwards, face a mask of disgust, sword ready.

The glistening, translucent red sack oozed slowly towards them, drawn by the smell of their meat and blood. Ceria held her breath. Any sudden movement might alert them all. They had to be killed before they could turn themselves inside out and move into the deadly attack form.

She held up three fingers so the others could see and began counting down. Pisces' skeletons stood at the ready, rocks in hand and Yvlon raised her sword, aiming at the nearest Creler.

"Now!"

Instantly, Ksmvr stabbed two blades into the Crelers he was nearest to. Pisces threw fire at another, screaming curses as Yvlon stabbed hers. The Crelers reacted, making a horrible *gurbling* sound as their fleshy outer red sacs tried to pull back and expose their vicious innards. But it was too late.

In their softer forms they were far weaker to attack. Ceria shot an [Ice Spike] into one Creler and watched blood and its yellowish guts explode inside the balloon of its body. The three skeletons smashed their Crelers with rocks, hammering with feverish frenzy as yellow juices splattered everywhere.

Ultimately, only two managed to transform into their attack modes and they were swiftly smashed by Yvlon's gauntleted boot and one of Pisces' skeletons with a rock. Ceria stood with the others, panting as she watched the skeleton repeatedly hammer the twitching Creler until it was in pieces.

"Let's never do that again."

Ceria panted as she and the others walked out of the nest. Yvlon and Pisces nodded, and even Ksmvr shuddered a bit as he wiped his blades clean. No one liked fighting Crelers. An underground dungeon full of deadly traps and the possibilities of cave-ins was one thing, but Crelers?

Not Crelers.

"That's the door."

Ceria whispered it triumphantly as she and the others peeked around the last corner in the tunnel. It felt like forever had passed, but they'd gone no further than twenty paces looking for traps—it seemed time had triggered another one by the smooth melted parts of the wall and scorch marks—and seen the door.

It was a plain, wood door, innocuously set against the frame of the dark stone. Ceria didn't trust it one bit. It could be an illusion, a trap, any number of things. But upon trying the handle the skeleton had only rattled the doorknob futilely. It had even tried to bash the door in, to no effect.

"Just a magically enchanted door? I'm not buying it."

"Well, it could be laced with any number of traps. We've got to either knock it down or open it some other way. But if we're in the line of fire—"

"Cast spells at it from range?"

"Could work. My [Ice Spike] spell might do some damage."

"It's the best option we've got for long distance. Unless you picked up a better spell, Pisces?"

"No. Do it."

Ceria nodded. She poked her finger around the corner as the others moved back, shielding herself against the wall. The trap skeleton watched impassively as it stood next to the door, a casualty to whatever was about to happen.

Okay. [Ice Spike] and then get ready to run if need be. Ceria took a deep breath, and then cast.

"[Ice Spike]!"

The magical dagger of ice shot from her fingertip and *broke* against the door. Ceria tensed along with the others, but nothing happened. Slowly, they relaxed.

"Maybe just fortifications?"

"Probably. How's the corridor?"

"Skeleton's gone over it three times."

"I volunteer to test it."

"Ksmvr, don't be silly—"

"We have been sitting here for an hour. We must try something. Allow me."

"Wait—"

Yvlon reached for him, but the Antinium stepped out into the corridor. He paused, but no spell came. Slowly, he walked over to the door.

“Nothing. I shall attempt to break it.”

He raised his enchanted sword and stabbed it into the wood. The door resisted the blow, just as it had the [Ice Spike]. And it didn’t trigger a counterspell.

“What is your opinion?”

Ksmvr returned to the others as they conferred. Ceria pulled at her hair, trying to figure out if this was a devilishly clever trap, or just a door made to last forever.

“It might only activate once we break through.”

“Possible, possible.”

“We need to get near, Pisces. We’ll analyze it at close range, and then back away and try from a distance, okay?”

He nodded. Ceria and Pisces exchanged a glance, and then all four Horns of Hammerad crept towards the door.

Nothing happened. They sighed in relief, but Ceria warned Yvlon and Ksmvr.

“Okay, we’re just going to inspect the spell binding the door. If it’s a high-Tier enhancement spell, well, we might have to find another way in. Break through the rock maybe. But don’t touch it until we’re done, okay?”

The other two nodded and readied themselves. Ceria looked at Pisces, and then they reached out and magically inspected the door. Both frowned at around the same time.

“Odd. Look at how delicate this enchantment is, Pisces.”

He nodded as he traced the shimmering symbols and magical currents only they could see.

“Indeed. This is not ordinary reinforcement. There is a trap here. But what’s the trigger?”

The magic shimmered in front of Ceria. Or rather, not shimmered. It was impossible to describe how the magic looked to her with mere words. It was feeling as much as anything else. She delicately looked at the magic, and felt something odd.

“Is it...shifting?”

It was. The stationary spell was moving, reacting. Ceria’s heart immediately skipped a beat and she stood up to back away from the door. Yvlon lifted her shield instantly.

“What’s wrong? What’s happening?”

“Oh no. Oh—it’s reacting to us looking at it. *Run! Ru—*”

She'd just turned when *something* whined and engulfed her. Ceria blundered forwards, and then *crashed* into something which broke.

Bones.

A skeleton? Pisces' creation?

No. Not Pisces' skeleton. Bones. Piles of bones.

Ceria looked around. They were in a pit. A pit with filth all over the walls. Yvlon, Ksmvr, Pisces—not the skeletons. They looked around, scrambling to get up.

“What happened?”

“We were teleported! A trap! Get ready!”

Ceria whirled around, looking for movement, a deadly spell, a monster, anything. But she saw nothing.

Then something glowed. She turned and saw something on one of the walls. It was...flickering at her. She stared at it. A word? Writing?

No. A magical rune. Ceria instantly tried to look away, but it was too late. She'd already seen it! She tried to close her eyes, but—

“Nothing?”

She stared around. Nothing had happened. She looked over at Ksmvr. He was staring at the magical words. Then he looked at her.

“Ksmvr? Are you okay?”

He hesitated. Then the Antinium nodded. And then he shook his head.

“What?”

He paused.

“I—I am an Aberration. No. I am Antinium.”

“What do you mean? Aberration? Ksmvr?”

He hesitated.

“I—I—I—I—”

He kept repeating the word. Ceria stared at him. Was something wrong? But that was how Ksmvr always acted, wasn't it? Yes? No?

Why was she talking to an Antinium?

Suddenly, someone grabbed her from behind. Ceria screamed and turned, but it was only Pisces. He stared at her, eyes furious.

“Pisces, what's wr—”

“*What are you doing in bed, boy?*”

He screamed the words at her, spittle flying, face red. Ceria jerked backwards, but Pisces had a death-grip on her. He shouted in her ears.

“Fencing practice *begins at dawn!* Get moving, and I swear, if you shirk I’ll tan your back!”

Something was wrong. Something was right. Ceria knocked Pisces’ hand away and scrambled backwards. She looked around. Yvlon. What was a Yvlon?

“Who are you?”

She was looking down the tip of a sword. A tall, blonde woman stared down at Ceria, chin tilted imperiously upwards as she aimed the sword at Ceria’s nose.

“Explain this uncouth behavior at once. What have you done with me?”

“You? What are you—Yvlon?”

“Ylvon? That is my niece, child. I am Yenelaw Byres, and I *demand* to know what you have done. What sorcery is this?”

“I don’t know. I—”

Ceria hesitated. Something was wrong. Something was right. Wrong. Right. When two wrongs make a right, who was the shipwright?

“Get moving!”

Pisces howled at Yvlon, pointing his finger at her. She shifted her sword to him and he danced back, suddenly on guard.

“Oh? Angry, are you? Testing me? You’ll have to do better than that, brat.”

“I am Yennais Bryres. Who, pray, are you?”

“I—I—I—help me—I—I—”

Ksmvr was clutching at his head. Pisces and Yvlon were shouting at the same time. Someone had to do something! Ceria opened her mouth, but then realized something dreadful.

I’ve forgotten how to breathe.

She had to tell the others. But she couldn’t breathe! Ceria scrabbled at her throat. She’d tear it out! Then she’d be able to breathe through the hole!

Ksmvr stumbled over to her, head in his hands. Her hands?

“i reJEct. aBErRation Is NoT—I am Antinium. I ReFUSE. i—”

Pisces tapped Ceria on the shoulder. She gasped for air and then stared in horror at the man-sized Creler wearing dirty robes.

“Fencing is a noble art, young man. Don’t you agree? Well, we shall see you master the forms or you will go without dinner tonight.”

A butterfly made of steel turned to Ceria and opened its mouth into Erin’s smiling face.

“What am I doing here? Answer me! You there in the frock!”

She had to do something. Stab them! Stab herself! Didn't she have a skeleton somewhere around here?

Ceria reached for a dagger, but she'd forgotten what her hands were too. She stared at the pulsating flesh-thing on her hand and tried not to scream. Her palm opened up, and little eyes with twig-like legs started crawling out of the hole in her body.

Everything was normal. That was it. Her head twisted—almost of its own volition and stared around the dark room.

What was that on the wall? It had flashed in her mind so quickly she hadn't had time to read it. As the rest of the world melted away, Ceria saw the shining light again. This time she understood it perfectly.

[Insanity].

The word was insanity, written in magic, pulsating into Ceria's brain. She smiled at it and then threw up. Her vomit turned into dancing little bugs which tried to eat her until she smashed them with her feet.

Of course.

It all made sense.

3.03

Some call me a messenger. Others call me a barefoot runner. And crazy. Some call me a deliverer...of messages. A few people know me as [batman]. I think of myself as reasonably sane, but most people disagree. They have a lot of names for someone like me. But the little monster blocking my way just barks.

Dogs. I hate them so much. The mangy dog with off-white fur and brown spots barks again, showing his teeth. There's a definite growl in his tone—he's not just warning me, he's telling me he *will* attack given an opportunity.

That's fine. If he goes for me I'm kicking him and damn the consequences. I've always wanted to kick a dog. I'm not an animal hater, I'm just a dog hater.

Consider my position. I, Ryoka Griffin, am standing in the snow a few miles out from the lovely city of Celum, holding a small wrapped package in my hands as I face down a dog blocking the way towards a house. It's not my fault I'm here; I'm on a delivery. And I don't want to get bitten.

I've been bitten by dogs before. Twice, in fact. Both times while I was running. Back home, in my world that is, some people like to think their dogs don't need a leash. I respect their opinion, and invite them to share it with the local animal control officer. Dogs who aren't on leashes chase moving objects like me. And they bite.

Maybe it's just my genetics, or something in me the dogs don't like. Or maybe it's because I'm often a sweaty, adrenaline-filled unknown threat invading their perceived personal space at high speed that triggers their instincts to chase and attack. I don't know. But all I know is that every person who runs hates loose dogs.

Plus, I'm a barefoot runner. That means I'm even more anxious about bites, because I have what is for all intents and purposes, ten bite-sized snacks for a dog to rip off. The same problem goes for my hands, although I only have eight available snacks for a dog to chew on. A Goblin bit two of my fingers off a week ago. Fun story. I'm not keen to repeat it.

The dog barks at me again, and this time growls loudly. I hold still, meeting his eyes as he crouches, hackles bared. He's in my way. I need to get to that house to deliver my package, but the owner hasn't come out and I think shouting will make the dog run at me. So. What do I do?

Kick the dog. That's what about 90% of me wants to do. The other 10% is arguing that the dog is only defending his home and he's innocent and that I should practice restraint. I'm not inclined to listen to that opinion, but a fight in the snow against a dog isn't what I want right now. He's not a big dog; that is to say, not as big as a mastiff or a great dane, but he's not a poodle either.

He's just a dog. He deserves mercy.

But I really want to kick a dog. He's going to try and bite me the instant I move. Kick first, ask questions later.

And if I kick him, I'll *have* to hurt him badly which won't go down well with the owner. Not a good idea.

On the other hand, he, or possibly, she, is in clear violation with my longstanding agreement with nature* and I have no desire to find out if he has rabies. I'm still not sure if healing potions have the ability to cure diseases.

*The Ryoka-Nature Accord reads as follows: Get in my way and I will kill and eat you.

This is how my day starts. On the whole, I've had better days.

"Hark! 'Tis a mutt and a lying Human-thing!"

"Girl versus dog! As good as girl versus Dragon! Will there be more riddles?"

And my day just got worse. I glance up as I hear the familiar, high-pitched voices from overhead. Spiraling down out of the grey skies overhead, small, winged creatures laugh and point at me and the dog.

I guess you could say they look like small versions of Humans, scaled down, painted blue and given wings. But that would completely, utterly fail to describe these beings. Because they are faeries. The fae. And they cannot be compared to us so easily.

Yes, the Frost Faeries or Winter Sprites as they are known look humanoid. But their bodies are part crystal, part ice. And they have wings, but they are closer to an insect's set of wings than an angel's. And in every facet of every line that makes up their beings, they are breathtakingly beautiful.

Not just beautiful; otherworldly. To look at the Frost Faeries is to believe in magic, because that is the whole of what they are. Even as I watch, they fly around me, laughing and speaking in voices that are also part real, and partly immortal.

“Look, sisters! The dog defends its home!”

“Let's eat it!”

“Nae, let us give it a charge! The power to destroy any invaders!”

“Are there any cats?”

They fly around me and the dog, poking, throwing snow into my eyes and raining it on the poor mutt. Oh yeah. I sometimes forget, but the faeries helpfully remind me—immortal wonders they might be, but they're also annoying as hell.

Only, in this case the faeries' arrival has an unintended benefit. The dog takes one look at the faeries and runs *yipping* into the house. I don't know if he can see the Frost Faeries—they're pretty much fuzzy blobs to anyone in this world thanks to the magic they wield—but he knows better than to stick around where they can get to him.

I'm not so lucky. The faeries fly around me, laughing, calling me names, teasing me. Some land on my hair which immediately freezes stiff, and others throw snow at my eyes. One drops a frozen beetle on my head.

I think they like me. I've experienced them not liking me, and this is still preferable. But it is annoying. I curse and swat at them with my injured hand. The one with three fingers.

“Get lost! I'm working!”

“Ooh! Scary! And what if we don't?”

“Yes, threaten us! What would ye do?”

The faeries know I can't back up any threats, so I don't bother making them. I sigh and take my hand away from my belt. I had been grasping

another bottle with my finger on the cork while facing down the dog. If kicking didn't work I was going to hit it with a potion full of eye-destroying pepper concentrate, although that *would* have been animal cruelty.

I can hear the dog that fled inside the house barking in fear, and now he pokes his head out the half-open door he first charged out at me from. The faeries throw snow at him and he whines in fear, but, credit where credit is due, he still doesn't want to leave me alone.

"Barky!"

A young voice shouts from inside the house. The door opens wider, and now a girl runs out. She's maybe eight or nine, and the dog anxiously runs out after her, circling around her. The girl takes no notice of the faeries, but stares at me.

"Who're you? Are you trying to hurt Barky?"

Instantly I regret my kicking-dog thoughts. A bit. The little girl stares at me with big, round eyes that creep me out.

"What are you here for?"

"I'm a Runner. Are your parents around?"

"A Runner?"

She looks doubtful, so I reach into my pouch and pull out a small Seal of my own. The magic metal and stone forged into a circle glints as I show it to the girl. It's proof I'm a City Runner; without it she would be right to be nervous.

"A Runner!"

"That's right. I have a delivery for your father. Is he here?"

"No—but I have a Seal! I'll go get it!"

The girl runs inside the house. The dog takes one look at us and runs in after her. The faeries and I wait as I shift from bare foot to foot in the snow. After a few seconds the door opens again and the girl runs out.

"Here, Miss Runner!"

"Thanks."

I hand the package over to the girl. She takes it carefully; it's bulky and wrapped heavily. I have no idea what's in it, but at least she won't drop it.

"Alright then, take care."

"Goodbye Miss Runner!"

The girl beams at me, and the dog barks. I try to smile; fail. Then she looks at my feet and gasps.

"Aren't your feet cold?"

I look down at my bare feet. They're resting in the snow which practically covers them, melting the cold ground, but I barely feel a thing. I grin at her.

"Nope. I've got magic feet."

"Really?"

She gapes at me, and I make tracks before she can ask any questions. The dog barks a few more times as I leave, but I'm willing to give him that. So long as he doesn't chase after me. I check my shoulders a few more times, but he stays with the girl.

Good dog. The faeries on the other hand aren't quite so well behaved.

"Hah! The waif has a loyal dog! Like the king and the Hound of Culann!"

"What was that she said? Magic feet?"

"How? Where did ye get them, mortal!"

"Yes, explain! Explain!"

They begin jumping up and down on my head as I pick up speed. I try to ignore them.

Despite the cold air and deep snow, I barely feel the chill as I run away from the farmhouse that I was making a delivery to. In the distance, the relatively tall walls of Celum beckon me. It's just past dawn and I've got more deliveries to make. And I'll make them in record time thanks to—

"Explain!"

Someone pulls at my hair and I grit my teeth.

"Stop that! I don't have magic feet. I drank some soup, okay? Magic soup."

"Oh."

The tiny voice on top of my head sounds disappointed. So do the rest of the faeries. I guess magic soup isn't as cool as magic feet. But then I hear another voice.

"I want to try some."

“Me too!”

“Give us the soup, Human!”

“The soup! The soup!”

They begin harassing me again. I try not to pay attention as I run back towards the city.

Magic soup. Yeah.

Did I mention I was in another world?

After the dog incident, I make good time running back to Celum. It's not as if I was that far away from the city, and I only had two more deliveries to make in the outer suburbs.

Fun fact: unlike the Drake cities to the south, Human cities may have walls, but their actual population likes to live outside the walls in lovely suburbs that nestle right up against the walls in some places. It's that old medieval-style method of building that allows cities to house a much larger population. If monsters attack, people just run inside the walls until they're gone and rebuild if they have to.

I wonder how well that worked in Esthelm. Given that the entire city was pretty much razed, I'm guessing there might be a teeny flaw in this system.

But it's not my job to give architectural advice to people. In fact, the only words I speak are when people open their doors.

“Do you know how *early* it is? Who're you?”

“I'm a Runner with a delivery. Do you have a Seal?”

“What? You're a Street Runner?”

“City Runner. I'm doing local deliveries. Do you have a Seal?”

“That's...quick. Normally we get messages late.”

“So I've been told. Your Seal?”

Eventually I get the Seal and hand the letter over to the person at the door and run away. That's what my job is all about. The talking and dodging dogs—that's the worst part. I'm just in it for the running.

Too bad everything seems to get in my way. Of course, that's my unbiased opinion; what could be more important than me delivering letters

to people? Guardsmen on patrol? Merchants and farmers with their wagons?

Bah. All of that is less important than the almighty Runner. I dodge and weave around pedestrians, run down less-crowded back alleys and avoid the hell out of any carts rumbling down the wet streets, all the while being followed by my annoying entourage of faeries.

I must admit, for all I hate their fascination with me, they do help clear the crowds. In this world, the Frost Faeries are simply known as strange creatures that help bring the winter each year. Because they can't be heard and barely be seen by the people here, they're generally treated like natural hazards to be avoided at all costs.

Too bad I can see them. I'm still not sure why, but that's led to me striking up an odd relationship up with the faeries. Namely, they annoy me and follow me about hoping I do something entertaining.

Like slip. I windmill my arms, but I still smack hard into the ground. The faeries—and some of the Humans walking by—chuckle, but I get back to my feet without a word and keep running. I swear that ice patch wasn't there a second ago.

“Did you enjoy your fall? Be more careful next time!”

“Take care not to slip, Human.”

“We tripped you! Hah!”

Damn faeries. I keep running, ignoring them as best I can. People give me odd looks if I start talking to the air in any case.

“Ooh. So busy! Too busy to talk!”

One of the faeries on my head slaps at my head to get my attention. I grit my teeth and ignore her, although it *hurts*. Then she pulls at my eyelid.

“Screw you! Off!”

I slap at her and she flies away, cheering. I guess getting me to react counts as a win in her books. Another faerie swoops down and flies around my face, obstructing my vision as she laughs.

“This mortal is so busy. Not too busy to play a game of riddles, though!”

“‘Twas not a fair game, though! She used numbers and lies instead of trickery! Shame!”

The other faeries jeer and yell at me. I keep a straight face, although the fact that I’m being berated by these obnoxious idiots for playing unfair is hilarious. They’re the most unrepentantly vicious, mischievous, and deceitful creatures I’ve ever met, and those are the qualities I *like* about them.

The Frost Faeries continue to call me names as I run back into the city proper. I get the sense that despite their obnoxious tone, today they’re a bit more annoyed with me than usual. How do I know? A bit more ice mixed in with the snow they toss on me, and a bit too many pinches and pokes than usual.

Normally the faeries respect—well, they’re equally parts helpful as annoying. Twice as annoying as helpful, but they do have limits. But I think they were disappointed in my game of riddles with Teriarch, the Dragon, a while back.

Yeah. A Dragon. I can barely believe it, but I did meet him. I keep telling myself that, although my only proof is the bag of gold at my side and the book of magic spells. Gods, I still can’t believe I walked away with part of a Dragon’s treasure.

It was a wonderful, magical encounter. But the faeries got mad because instead of having a proper Smeagol vs Bilbo game of riddles, I instead hit Teriarch with logic puzzles from my world. Apparently that doesn’t count and they’re mad about it.

Or something. I finally get rid of the faeries as I go one place they can’t stand: indoors. As I run towards a familiar building, all the faeries *hiss* and leap off my head. They throw snow at me as I open the door to the Runner’s Guild and slip inside. The building is made with nails of iron and it has iron in general inside; ergo the faeries don’t feel welcome and don’t follow. Their rules are bizarre, but I’m glad they exist.

“Done with the deliveries.”

The [Receptionist] at the counter looks up and gives me a smile which I don’t return. I hand her the Seals I’ve been given and she confirms all my deliveries are done.

“That was quick, Miss Ryoka! I gave them to you just an hour ago, didn’t I?”

I shrug. I was given five different locations. I got to them all, and got the seals. And I did it fast, too.

“Yep. Got any more?”

The [Receptionist] glances awkwardly at the board of deliveries. I look over there too, and notice some other Runners congregated around it. Only one or two today, though.

Normally, longer deliveries are posted on the board – these would be city-to-city runs, the kind I normally do. But there aren’t many requests or many of the better type of Runner that can avoid or outrun bandits and monsters—City Runners—around. That’s because of the Goblins. No one wants to run into them, even if none have been spotted on the roads as of yet.

“I’m afraid we’re all out of Street Runner deliveries. You and the other City Runners—”

I glance over and see where the receptionist is looking. The Runner’s Guild has tables and places to sit, and they’re occupied by an annoyed-looking group of younger Runners. They’re all Street Runners, by the looks of them. They’re not as quick as City Runners, and though they might know the streets well, I and the other City Runners can still beat them in speed. We’ve been cooped up in the city, and so we’ve been poaching all their regular deliveries.

Do I feel bad? No, not really. Running, doing deliveries, it’s all a competition in a way. I run fast, and so I get paid more. Maybe I’d try to give them some work if I intended to stay here for a while, but I think this is my last day of running solely around the city.

I turn back to the receptionist and nod.

“Fine, I’ll come back later. Is Garia Strongheart around?”

“Miss Garia? I haven’t seen her yet. Do you want to leave a message for her?”

“Just tell her I’d like to talk to her if she comes in. That’s all.”

“I will do so. Have a good day, Miss R—”

I’m out the door before the [Receptionist] finishes speaking. Was that rude? Yes, it probably was. She was only trying to do her job, but I didn’t want to exchange pleasantries. It’s a bad habit of mine, and I’ve been getting better recently.

But today? Today’s a bit...frustrating for me. Scratch that, I just woke up so I can’t really say it’s been frustrating as of yet. More like I’ve been

having problems for the last few days and today it's just...

I jog down the streets, keeping an eye out for Frost Faeries. They're probably bothering someone else right now, but I want to get to my destination before they come back to check on me. Sure enough, I spot the familiar building and push the door open.

Unlike the Runner's Guild, I hear a babble of voices and find a full house the instant I walk in. Barmaids—three of them—bustle about the room, filling mugs and tankards and serving food to the room full of people eating breakfast.

That's pretty normal for an inn. But this inn is special, if only because it's under new management. The evidence of that is clear when I stare at what one of the barmaids is serving to the guests.

"Crepes?"

Yep. They're crepes alright, complete with sprinkled sugar, and lots of butter. Not any syrup; I guess it's too expensive for this inn's budget. But eggs and bacon make this a filling meal—and food choice aside, I can see that each crepe is golden brown and cooked perfectly.

The small inn I'm staying at, the Frenzied Hare, is packed today, just like it was yesterday. Although we've only been in the city for a few days, word has gotten around that there's a new [Innkeeper] who makes great food, and so every day the common room is packed full of people.

Again, thanks to the new management. I'm not sure if she owns the inn, but she acts as if she does and everyone goes along with her because frankly, she's pulling in money by the bagful. I walk into the kitchen and see the mastermind behind today's breakfast flipping a crepe into the air. She holds out a plate to catch it, and it splats into the bowl of batter. I block some of the splatter with my hands as she exclaims.

"Ew! I guess [Advanced Cooking] doesn't help with *that*."

She wipes some of the batter off her apron and licks it. Then she looks around and sees me.

"Hey Ryoka! Want a crepe?"

I wipe the batter on my hands and shirt off onto an apron, suddenly realizing that I probably shouldn't be walking in here with my wet and dirty feet. Oh well.

"I'll have some food, Erin. Do you want to have breakfast together or have you eaten?"

“Um...I’ve made breakfast, but haven’t eaten. Let me just make one last stack—I think everyone out there is mostly done! I’ll be with you in a bit.”

“Gotcha.”

I walk back out into the inn and try to find an empty table. One of the barmaids who’s name I keep forgetting comes over with a plate of crepes.

“Anything you want to drink, Miss Ryoka? Or is it just hot water again?”

“Hot water. And Erin will probably have milk. She’ll be out in a bit.”

“I’ll be back with your drinks in a second!”

The young woman smiles at me and moves over to another table. I start cutting my crepe apart and eating it. It’s delicious, and the eggs and bacon I manage to get another barmaid to give me are just as good. But my eyes are on the kitchen, and soon enough I see her come out of it.

Erin Solstice. The inn doesn’t exactly stop for her, but somehow she makes her own impression on it. As soon as she comes out she looks towards me. I raise my hand, but she’s intercepted before she even sees me.

The actual owner of the Frenzied Hare, Agnes, has a plate of food in one hand and a huge smile on her face. She’s acting as a barmaid rather than as the innkeeper, but she couldn’t be happier judging by the look on her face as she sits Erin down at a table. She chats animatedly with Erin and other guests come over.

That’s part of Erin’s charm, I guess. She’s friendly, open, and frankly interesting. As an [Innkeeper], I gather she’s quite high-level, especially at her age. You could call her a prodigy without exaggerating, at least by how this world judges things.

Erin has many Skills in the [Innkeeper] class that makes her useful in any inn she walks into, and in a fight. She’s also got great charisma, which is why I finish two plates of food and Erin’s drink of milk before she even finishes her first plate. She’s so busy chatting with Agnes and some other people that I have to wait a few minutes before I can even get her attention.

“Oh, hey Ryoka! Sorry, I must have missed you! Agnes was just telling me I should stay here and help her run the inn forever!”

The woman chuckles as she sits next to Erin, eating the crepes.

“It would be lovely if you would. You’re such a good cook and frankly my dear—you have such a way about you that even Jerom would be jealous of. He’s still so sick—but even when he gets better I could see you being

the real manager of the inn. Why, you're like a second child to me—not that I had a first. I'd so love it if you gave it some thought."

I roll my eyes as Erin smiles and says something polite and friendly in reply. A second child, sure. One that can do Agnes' job and her husband's without even needing them. Erin is a golden goose and they just want her to stay here and earn them tons of money forever. Even though she's splitting the profits with Agnes, they have to be earning more in these few days than they would in a month.

Maybe I'm being too harsh. Agnes looks genuinely happy to have Erin here, and so do the other people. But I'm not going to wait until they finish their chat about banal things. I clear my throat.

"Erin. Do you have a minute?"

She looks up at me and nods, while the others look disappointed.

"Sure, Ryoka! Let me just eat one last crepe...mm, this is good! You want another?"

I shake my head and wait until Erin finishes stuffing her face. Of course, that doesn't mean she and I get to talk right away. Agnes hovers around while Erin chats with her...and then some of her guests...and then finally has time to talk with me at a table in the corner.

"What's up, Ryoka? Did you finish your deliveries?"

"A while ago. But I was thinking today you and I should do more planning. We still need to get you back."

Erin's smile, present on her face since the moment I saw her today, fades. She looks at me seriously.

"Right. We still need to get back. But didn't you say that was dangerous? You told me yesterday that leaving wasn't a good idea."

I nod. Erin and I are in Celum, a Human city on the continent of Izril. And while we're surviving well enough here, this isn't where Erin belongs. She needs to go back to Liscor, a city a hundred miles south of here, and that is an undertaking which has been bothering me since I found her here.

"Right, leaving earlier wasn't a good option. The gates were locked for the first day, and we were still getting word of what happened yesterday. But there aren't any reports of large Goblin groups on the move today, so if we're going to look into getting you back to Liscor, we should start now."

Liscor is Erin's home. At least, that's where her inn is. And her friends. She belongs there, in a sense, and both she and I know it, no matter how much she might enjoy being here.

Erin frowns as she nods and drinks from her cup of warm milk.

“I want to go back, Ryoka, I really do. I know Mrsha must be so worried! But Selys can take care of her, and I really do want to finish up my experiments with Octavia first.”

I frown at Erin. She keeps saying she wants to finish her experiments, but over the three days we’ve been here, she’s gone to the [Alchemist]’s shop nearly every day.

“Aren’t you done yet? Or can’t you finish your work in Liscor?”

“Maybe...but I need Octavia’s help, Ryoka! She knows all kinds of rare alchemical stuff and she helps me with the food.”

Magical food. Only Erin would think of it. But it works—she made a soup that can give me partial immunity to the cold. I clench my teeth as I think.

“If I had to choose between you going now or later...there are [Alchemists] in Liscor, I’m sure, Erin. And maybe we could get Octavia to come with you? She’d do anything for gold.”

“Maybe.”

“Either way, I want to know that we can get you back, so I wanted to visit places with you if you’ve got time before you go to Octavia’s. There’s a market full of magical items—I want to see if there’s anything you or I could use in case we got attacked on the road—and the Adventurer’s Guild might have a party we could hire to escort us back.”

Erin’s eyes light up at the sound of magical items. She’s still not over magic existing in this world, and neither am I, in truth. She nods eagerly as she finishes her drink.

“I’d love to come along! Agnes says she can handle lunch, so as long as I’m back for dinner—I’m sure Octavia wouldn’t mind if I came by an hour or two late.”

I’m sure she wouldn’t. I nod briskly as Erin waves at Agnes to let her know.

“Fine. First we go shopping, then we’ll ask about an escort and visit Octavia. Sound good?”

“Great!”

“Oh, and by the way, the Frost Faeries are back.”

“Oh. Um...”

It takes us a while to leave the inn, but by the time we do, thirty more minutes have passed, and the faeries are waiting for us as we leave.

“Oh look! It’s the duo! The food maker and the story teller!”

“Let’s hit them with snow!”

“Nae, let’s demand food and a story!”

Erin blinks up at the faeries as I groan. The other guests that came out to talk and socialize with Erin immediately decide to go back in as the tiny faeries begin swirling around us again, pulling at hair, laughing, conjuring snow—

“Hey, do you all want a crepe?”

They blink. I blink. But the steaming crepe is in Erin’s hands and she tosses it up to them. Immediately, all the faeries begin to fight over it.

“Give it to me!”

“No, me!”

In an instant the crepe is whirled up into the air and bits of it fall down as the faeries fight and devour it, ripping head-sized chunks away and gobbling them down like starving...ladybugs. Well, they’re bigger than ladybugs by a good bit, but you get the idea.

While they’re fighting, Erin and I walk off. I see the door open behind us, and to my surprise, a plate heaping with steamed crepes is placed outside. I see Agnes waving at Erin before she closes the door and the faeries descend on the food.

I stare at Erin as she smiles, walking beside me.

“Did you plan that?”

“Yeah, they like food!”

Why didn’t I think of—I walk along with Erin, shaking my head slightly. Bribe the faeries with crepes. It’s so obvious, and so easy!

That’s the thing about Erin. It’s never boring when I’m with her. In fact, she might have an even crazier life than I do at times.

“So, all of these things are magical?”

Erin and I stand in what I can only call a cross between a flea market and a shopping street, staring at a merchant as he displays a small selection

of old-looking rings, amulets, and even a few neatly tied scrolls.

Like all markets, supply is often matched by demand, which is why finding anyone who sells magical items in Celum is actually a harder task than it might seem. There are very few shops that do permanent trade in solely magical items, and most such merchants roam from city to city to find their clientele.

Erin and I were lucky enough to be pointed towards this [Merchant], a man of good repute who offers lower-grade magical items. He's a richly dressed man wearing countless rings and jewelry that sparkles and gives the impression of magic—although I doubt the rings do much more than emit pretty colors. The effect is nice, though, and the man himself is quite the salesman, trying to get Erin or I to commit to a purchase.

Frankly, I'm not sure I'll buy anything today. I've got Octavia's potions which are quite useful, and I don't have any glaring needs for magical artifacts right now. I'm just browsing. Also, from what I understand of how much any kind of enchanted object costs, I can only afford a very basic item even with the eight hundred gold pieces I received from Teriarch.

The man sits on a small wooden chair, watching us with a smile on his face while his two guards watch us and everyone coming near the display with considerably less cheer. Erin stares with fascination at the rings; they just look old and uninteresting to me, except for one ring that's visibly sparkling with red light. I guess most magical items are designed not to attract attention.

"Ladies, what would you two like to buy? I have quite a small selection today—I was cleaned out a while back, but I believe I have a number of trinkets that could help you with all your needs. In fact, I even have a little potion for romantic—"

"We're not shopping for love potions. I'm looking for protection."

I don't want to know if there are actual love potions in this world. The man blinks at me.

"Protection? Unless you need a weapon—no. Are you a Runner?"

"Well observed."

I lift one bare foot. The [Merchant] is eyeing my un-frostbitten toes, and I can tell he wants to ask about them.

"I'm looking for a ring of protection or something similar. Anything that can help me survive a run-in with monsters or bandits."

The man smiles thinly at me, and from the way the two guards shift, I can tell they're amused as well.

"Ah, I'm afraid you might be under a bit of a misapprehension, Miss. Protection is a very general term. There's no such thing as a ring that simply guards against everything—at least not outside of an artifact worth hundreds of thousands of gold coins—but let me show you what you're probably looking for in your line of work."

The [Merchant] gives me a not-at-all condescending smile that makes me want to deck him as he selects a ring from the items in front of him. He shows me the ring; a slightly cracked circle that feels like it's made of stone.

"This is a wonderful little trinket that I could sell you—for six hundred gold coins, say? It will deflect arrows for one minute when activated. Arrows will swerve as they fly towards you, perfect for a Runner like you to make their escape."

"Why's it cracked?"

Erin peers at the ring next to me. She touches the ring along the crack and the man practically snatches it back.

"*Please* don't touch that. The magic on this ring is slightly—faded. Hence the discount. But I can assure you it will last quite a long time if not subjected to undue pressure."

"Like an arrow?"

He ignores Erin and smiles at me.

"How about it? You could weather any storm of arrows—especially ones shot by Goblin archers. I'm sure you've heard about the attack on Esthelm? Tragic. But in your line of work, you can't afford to stay behind city walls, can you? This ring will allow you plenty of time to escape."

"For a minute."

"A minute. Yes."

Erin frowns as she stares at the ring. I keep my face straight and try to sound disinterested—I know how to haggle. But I'm more interested in seeing how Erin deals with this [Merchant]. I'm pretty sure I don't even want that crappy ring, but I do want to see the show. Erin points to the ring as she questions the man.

"A minute doesn't sound like much. How long does it take to recharge?"

He grits his teeth, although he's still smiling.

“Two days. But you can always recharge it if you have the gift, and I assure you—”

“—And what did you mean earlier? Arrows ‘swerve’? Does that mean it doesn’t really deflect them? Wait a second, why would anyone want a ring like that anyways?”

My lips twitch, and I even see the guards grinning a bit. The [Merchant]’s voice is testy.

“It’s true that the ring doesn’t send arrows in the other direction, but it does repel them from your person. *If* you are running, I’m confident the arrows would fail to hit their mark. It would take someone with a Skill to bypass the protection this ring offers, and again, let me say for five hundred and seventy gold coins, this ring is a bargain.”

“I bet Halrac could shoot an arrow that could beat your ring.”

“Who?”

“Halrac! He’s this guy—a [Scout] that I met at my inn. He’s really good with a bow, and he’s got tons of Skills. What would happen if he shot an arrow at this ring? Would it work?”

The man stares at Erin, brow furrowed.

“Halrac? You mean...Halrac of Griffon Hunt? The Gold-rank adventurer?”

“Yeah, that’s him. He’s a friend of ours. Do you know him?”

For two seconds the [Merchant] stares at Erin. Then he glances at something on his wrist. I look down. One of the gemstones on the man’s bestrewn hands is glowing softly blue. Oho. A truth spell on a stone?

At once, the man’s demeanor changes. He spreads his arms wide, all former irritation gone in a flash as he stands up, now trying to be very welcoming towards us.

“If you know Halrac, that’s different. You know, he bought a very nice amulet from a friend of mine just last year? I’d be very grateful if you’d recommend my wares to him. And for a friend of Halrac, I could certainly offer you...ah...”

He’s clearly trying to figure out what kind of discount and pitch he should give us when I hear familiar voices and groan through clenched teeth.

“There she is! Found her!”

“She can’t run away this time!”

“Ooh! Is she looking at magical items? Look how shiny they are! And how weak!”

“They barely glow of magic!”

Erin looks around, frowning. I’ve already spotted the Frost Faeries—they’re rising in a cloud over one of the roofs. Neither the guards nor the [Merchant] can hear the faeries of course, but they see us looking away and spot the faeries. They’re probably only glowing blurs to them, but all three react when they see the Winter Sprites.

“Not them!”

The [Merchant] exclaims in a loud voice, and one of the guards shouts a warning. Surprisingly, every single shopkeeper on the street suddenly begins to scramble, shouting as they grab at their wares and try to get everything inside.

The faeries fly down, laughing at the chaos as the man grabs at his magical rings and amulets, face suddenly hunted. Erin looks confused.

“Hey wait, where are you going? I thought you were going to sell us that bad ring!”

The man turns to us, looking frantic.

“Look, we’ll do business when the Winter Sprites are gone, alright? If I keep my wares out in the open they’ll scatter my goods and chase away all my customers!”

He rushes towards the nearest door, his guards grabbing the rest of his goods. Other shopkeepers do the same and the pedestrians scatter indoors as well, fearing the wrath of the fickle nuisances. In seconds, the street is deserted except for two humans and the faeries.

Erin and I stare up at the faeries. They stare back as they hover in the air, watching us. One of them waves.

After our short shopping trip in the market, the next place Erin and I decide to go is indoors, where the faeries can’t follow. And where we find ourselves is the Adventurer’s Guild. Erin and I stare around the big room as she whispers to me.

“It looks sort of like Selys’s guild, but not, don’t you think? I mean, this place is bigger. A lot bigger.”

I nod as I stare around the Adventurer's Guild in Celum. This place is certainly a lot bigger, and the room has space for up to six receptionists at once, rather than the single desk for two in Liscor's guild. I tap on the desk for the receptionist as I ask about hiring a team. She directs me towards the adventurers sitting in one corner of the room. Apparently, hiring an escort is done by contacting the adventurers directly, not through the guild here.

I stare at the groups of adventurers sitting together. Some are Bronze-rank, most are, probably. And others are Silver-rank, whether individually or in teams. A lot of them look tired, cleaning their equipment after some mission, and others look like they're just here to socialize.

Damnit. Which group should I talk to? What's the standard rate for hiring them? Can I trust a Silver-rank team? I know none of this.

Neither does Erin, but she has an almost insultingly cavalier attitude towards this.

"Let's just ask them. If any of them say they can take us to Liscor, let's try it!"

"You want me to just walk over there and ask them about escort duty?"

I hate talking to new people. I hate starting up conversations, and this is practically my worst nightmare. But Erin just shrugs at me. I grind my teeth.

"What do you expect me to say? 'Hey, we're looking for a group of adventurers to escort us to Liscor. Know anyone who might be interested?'"

"That sounds good. Why not?"

I stare at Erin. Well, it might work.

"You say it. I think it's best if it comes from you."

Erin nods and begins walking over to the nearest table where two brawny warriors are sitting and drinking together. Halfway there she turns back and looks at me with a smile of realization.

"You know who'd be great, Ryoka? The Horns of Hammerad! Why don't we just ask them?"

I blink. Oh. Of course. That would save costs or they could redirect us. I walk over towards Erin, but then one of the adventurers sitting at the table raises his voice?

"The Horns of Hammerad? Aren't they all dead?"

Erin beams at them.

"What? No! No, they've reformed, didn't you hear? After they uh—they lost people at the Ruins in Liscor—"

One of the men snorts. He's in his late twenties by the looks of him, and he's got day-old stubble on his face.

"I heard about that disaster. Four adventuring teams dead and only a handful of survivors thanks to a bunch of incompetent Captains. You're telling me someone's stupid enough to keep the name after that? They should have quit being adventurers before they ever went on another mission."

I stop in my tracks and bite my lips. Erin pauses, and the smile on her face freezes. The second adventurer looks at his companion.

"Who survived? I heard everyone got slaughtered down there."

"At least two made it out. The half-Elf and the Silver Captain."

"Ceria Springwalker and Yvlon Byres? I wouldn't join a group with those two even if they were the last team on the continent. Anyone stupid enough to work with them is going to get killed like their last groups."

Don't punch them. I know that. Erin's voice is flat.

"They're both great adventurers. They're my friends."

The two men shake their heads at her.

"They're idiots and cowards who got good folk who trusted them killed."

"You might think they're on your side, but mark my words, girl. Trust them and you'll end up with an arrow in your back."

They don't even bother lowering their voices. People at other tables look up as they hear the two men begin to argue with Erin.

"That's not true! Ceria's really brave! So is Yvlon!"

"The half-Elf? I bet she turned and ran the instant she got into trouble. She's a coward. Calruz was the only real fighter in the Horns of Hammerad."

"Take that back!"

Erin's getting mad, and I'm eying the two men seated at their table. They look a lot tougher than the adventurers Erin got into a fight with at her inn. And they're just talking, not sexually harassing anyone.

But my blood is still boiling. The Horns of Hammerad don't deserve this. They were all brave, and I could tell them that, but what would be the point? The two sneering men clearly don't want to listen; the best thing I could do is kick them both in the face.

I could start a fight—

But I close my hand and feel the stumps of my fingers. No. Not here. Not now. We need the help of some adventurers, even if it's not them.

I put my hand on Erin's shoulder. She's tense and glaring.

"Come on, Erin. Let's talk to someone else."

"If you want *real* protection, Miss, you'd best ask us or a real Silver-rank team. Not a bunch of half-wits that can't even slay a few undead."

I have to drag Erin backwards. She glares at me, but I manage to pull her back successfully. Five steps. Then I run into someone.

"Oh, sorr—"

I pause as I stare into a familiar, beat-up face. An adventurer pauses with four of his buddies as they walk towards the receptionist's desk. All of them look beat-upon; the result of a bar fight they were on the losing end of.

The lead adventurer certainly recognizes me.

He takes one look at Erin and begins edging towards the door. Too late. As my grip slackens, Erin pulls herself away. She walks back over to the table with the two adventurers and smiles at them as she puts her hands on the edge of the table.

"You should take back what you said about Ceria and Yvlon. They're my friends and they did everything they could to keep everyone else alive."

"We said exactly what everyone else was thinking, Miss. The Horns of Hammerad—both past and present—are a team of fools."

Erin takes a deep breath. Her eyes are wide and she gives them a big smile.

"Okay. Fine. If that's the way it's gonna be then—*table flip attack!*"

On the whole, I sometimes wonder if Erin's the more violent one between the two of us.

"Well, now we're banned from the Adventurer's Guild. At least for a while."

I sigh as Erin and I stump along down the street, followed by a cloud of faeries. I'm resigned to them by this point. They fly after us, laughing about the fight. Erin walks behind me, frowning.

"I don't regret a thing! Those guys were jerks!"

“Yeah, they were. But now they won’t help us if we need to get back to Liscor.”

“So? We’ll just get the Horns of Hammerad to do it. Ceria and Pisces and Yvlon and Ksmvr can probably defend us against anything we run up against.”

“Maybe. But we don’t know where they are. I can try and make a trip to Albez—or put the word out I’m looking for them in other cities, but it’ll take longer.”

“That’s fine.”

Erin nods, and I glance up at the faeries flying overhead. They look... slightly bored, actually. They’re still laughing and one of them is dropping a steady stream of powdery snowflakes into my eyes, but the rest are just following along, quiet for once.

Huh. I guess even faeries get bored. I shrug and keep walking.

“I’m going to do another delivery—to another city probably. I’ll be back tonight unless something comes up. You okay until then?”

“I’m gonna blow something up.”

I grin.

“That sounds like fun. Just try not to piss Octavia off too much, okay?”

I try to drop Erin off at the [Alchemist]’s shop, but to my surprise Octavia herself runs out, waving one of her arms at me as if it’s a club.

“Ryoka? *Ryoka!*”

Erin walks happily into the shop as the stitch-girl confronts me. Octavia looks stressed out, sort of understandable given that she’s going to be babysitting Erin all day today. Again.

“Hey Octavia, Erin wants to blow something up.”

The young woman’s dark skinned face goes pale as she looks back at Erin in her shop. I feel a bit bad, so I try to reassure her.

“She probably won’t. She’s looking forwards to experimenting with new food recipes, Octavia.”

“Absolutely not! Do you know how much she’s cost me already? One day was in our agreement. I could see two days, maybe three in light of our past arrangements and for future business’s sake, but four? Erin’s already cost me a small fortune in ingredients, not to mention all the time I could be making my own potions. If I’ve got to keep helping her out I insist on some kind of reimbursement. I know we had a bargain, but *this*—”

I have to take a step back as Octavia shouts and waves her hands at me. Looks like she's hit the end of her patience. Damn. What should I do?

I hesitate, then take the most expedient course of action. Octavia's ranting slows and stops dead as I start pulling gold coins out of the bag at my side. From the looks of it, it shouldn't be able to hold all the gold that's in there, but it's magical. There's a massive book inside as well, and that still amazes me.

"Fine. I get it. Here's more money for Erin, okay?"

I pour the gold into Octavia's hands as the [Alchemist] gapes at me. Twenty golden coins—pretty darn heavy and glittering in the light, wink up at the girl as she looks from the money to me.

Twenty gold coins. Yes, it's a lot, but it's only a fraction of the money I got from Teriarch. And by the way Octavia goes silent, it's a lot more than she thought she'd get.

"So. Is there a problem with Erin?"

"Erin? What? Of course not!"

Octavia beams.

"Erin, my favorite customer. I'd be happy to—let me just say that as long as she wants to keep working with me, I'd be delighted to help out. Her achievements really are stellar, and let me tell you that I think she's onto a real breakthrough—"

"Glad to hear it. Just get her whatever she wants, Octavia."

I let the [Alchemist] practically skip back into her shop and walk off, shaking my head. The faeries follow me, half imitating my shaking head motion, the other half debating whether it would be more enjoyable to watch Erin blow something up in the shop.

I don't know. I'm glad that Erin's happy, and I'm fine with leaving her alone to cause havoc in Octavia's shop. She'll probably be fine with Octavia to stop her from doing something too insane.

But—

I'm just a bit tired. At the end of my rope, you could say. It's not that I don't have anything to do; I've got too much to do.

Time to go on another delivery. I start walking in the direction of the Runner's Guild again. I might not be feeling at the top of my game, but at least I can always count on running to take the stress away.

“I’m looking for a delivery to another city, but I can’t find any requests. Do you have any?”

The receptionist in the Runner’s Guild looks up at me and frowns. She taps one finger against her lips and nods at last.

“We...have the daily letter delivery for Wales if you’re interested.”

Her hesitation is warranted. No one likes that delivery. I make a face.

“Nothing else?”

“Nothing. Sorry Miss Ryoka.”

The [Receptionist] shrinks back slightly in her seat as I stare at her. After a minute I nod.

“Fine. Give me that delivery.”

I run through the snow, and then onto harder, slippery ground that’s been frozen over and not thawed. I frown and run back into the snow. It might be more constricting, but thanks to Erin’s soup that I took another drink of before I left, it’s easier to run through the grass underneath the snow than the slippery road.

I’m doing the bulk letter delivery to Wales. It’s...well, it’s not exactly anything to write home about. Or anywhere else for that matter.

Bulk delivery. Just like the post office, letters are taken in and a huge bag full of them is sent off with a City Runner each day to the other cities. It’s a standard delivery, and since it’s so easy, it pays next to nothing.

I haven’t done it since I started working as a Runner. Where did all the big deliveries go? Do people just not need anything during the winter months? No, that can’t be true. Must just be a slow day.

But, like always, I’m not alone. A cloud of faeries flies around me, watching me with heavy-lidded eyes as I run at a good pace through the snow. But all the faces of the faeries aren’t filled with their usual calculated expressions of glee or anticipation. Instead, they all look bored.

It’s actually sort of bugging me. I glance around at the faeries. Some are frowning, and I rarely see them do that. Why haven’t they gone to bother someone else? But then one flying furthest from me speaks, and I hear her voice clearly over the rushing wind.

“No. This is boring. I don’t want to do it anymore.”

That’s odd. I stare at the faerie who said that. She has a very unhappy expression on her face. She flies into the center of the herd of faeries and raises her voice as she points at me.

“You’re boring now. *Boring*. Mortal, do something interesting.”

“I’m no one’s monkey. Get lost.”

I wave at the faerie as she flies around me. She blows ice fragments into my face, making me curse and nearly trip as she shouts at the other faeries.

“See? She does naught! I won’t follow anymore. Not even if a Wyvern flew down and dragged her screaming into the air!”

All the faeries look up hopefully. So do I. Nothing. The faerie makes a disgusted sound.

“I am done. There are other places to be, other mortals to watch and bother. Not her.”

That sounds completely fine to me. Why wouldn’t the faeries go annoy someone else if I’m not entertaining them? They’ve done so before.

But this time, the faerie’s words seem to have a lot more significance to them. The other faeries exchange looks, and then begin to argue overhead.

“But she wants—”

“Nae, I don’t care as well! We’ve done this too long!”

“Yeah! She went to the *Dragon* and nothing happened!”

“I’m going!”

“Me too!”

“I’m staying. No. Wait. I’m going too!”

“Let’s go bother a King! Or a Queen!”

“I want to eat berries in the jungle!”

The faeries...begin flying away. They flutter upwards in a storm of flashing wings and movement. I stare up at them, my heart beating out of

my chest for some reason.

They're going? Forever? Or will they come back? What they said—
I don't mind. Not at all. If the Frost Faeries leave me alone, no one will
be happier than I...

I stumble on something in the snow. When I raise my foot, I see blood.
Cut my skin on a bit of rock. Damn.

Then I look up, and they're gone. The sky is clear, and the faeries—
The Frost Faeries are gone. The winter they brought remains, but the
magic has left. I feel empty. Relieved?

No. Not relieved. They're gone, and I don't know why.

I turn back to my run. Don't think about it. Why would they do that?
What did they mean? How was I boring? Was it something I did? What was
so wrong about the game of riddles with Teriarch?

A flash of liquid ice to my left. My head snaps around so fast I hear a
crick.

They're not all gone. I see a pale blue shape flying in the air beside me.
A Frost Faerie, easily keeping pace with me as I run through the snowy
landscape.

One of them is still following. Just one, flying up and to my right,
sitting in the air as her wings beat disproportionately slowly to the speed
she's going. Just one.

For some reason, the tension in my heart eases. I feel a bit lighter,
although I don't know why. I stare at the faerie and nearly trip again. She
waves at me and grins.

Why is she here? I open my mouth to ask, and then see something to my
right. Something closing in fast.

Instantly, I reach for a potion at my belt and slow as I fixate on that,
forgetting completely about the faerie. I see a blur—something racing
through the snow, and—is that laughter? And I see a pale, pinched face, and
catch a glimpse of someone for just one second before she's past me,
speeding down the frozen road at a pace I could never match.

I come to a dead stop in the snow, my feet melting the snow I stand on
as I stare at the already distant figure running past me, towards another city.

No way. It can't be. But I say it out loud anyways.

"Is that...Persua?"

I have no idea. I think it was Persua. She has that same sallow* face and annoying complexion as ever, and her running form was crap.

*I know sallow isn't the right word, but I'm still using it for her. Pinched is probably a better word, but I like sallow.

But the way she moved! She was moving faster than I was—way faster. How? No, I know how. A Skill. But can it really happen that fast? Persua was the slowest City Runner I knew, even slower than Garia because she took regular breaks. And now—

I shake my head as I sit in the small room I've rented in the Frenzied Hare. Erin's got her own room for which I'm grateful; I need the alone time right now.

I finished my delivery. It was an easy thing; I don't even have to track down the individual recipients myself with a bulk delivery. I just hand it over to the receptionist at the local Runner's Guild and get my pay.

Easy. And now I'm relaxing in my room, using the few hours I have before dinner to do some studying. Not dwelling on Persua; studying.

I sigh and look back at the massive tome in front of me. A book—a magical spell book lies on the table in front of me, so big there's nowhere else on the table for me to put anything else.

I'm studying magic. That's what I've been doing every day, while Erin causes havoc in Octavia's shop and generally runs about the city. I've cut back on doing my deliveries to make time for this.

Learning magic. Learning spells from the tome of wonders that Teriarch gave me. And how many new spells have I learned today?

Well, none, actually. And how many did I learn yesterday?

None, again. In fact, ever since I opened the book to this page I've been...

Stuck.

I stare down at the page covered with words that are part magic, part language. They shine at me, spelling out secrets in the magical language that I can only comprehend at a snail's pace. But I can read the words—

I just can't accept what they say.

I raise my hand, and take a breath. It's not that warm in my room; there's not exactly central heating in this building, although heat does come

up from the ground floor. But it's chilly even so, and I opened the window to let some air in, despite the freezing cold outside. None of the windows in this inn have glass, so either I keep the shutters closed and suffocate, or face the weather.

Ignore that. Concentrate. I fix all my attention on my hand and try to push an invisible force into the right place. Let it condense, like rainwater. Make it into a current and *push*—

“[Water Spray].”

I say the words, and try to use the magic. But nothing happens. I stare at my hand, and say the words again.

“[Water Spray].”

Again, my hand and the air around it are completely still.

“Damn it.”

It's not working. I look back at the page in the book and clench my fists. Another failure.

“It makes no sense. It's not—”

I take another breath, and try to exhale slowly. No. It's really not working, is it? I can't figure it out. This—

This isn't working.

I stand up and walk slowly around my cramped room. Yeah. I've been trying to put off this conclusion for a while. Day after day I've done this, but I'm no closer to the answer than I was yesterday. I have to call it. I have to say it.

“I can't do it.”

This is the real reason why every day hasn't been great. Stress, Goblins, all of my worries are one thing, but I think I could have handled it all if it wasn't for this.

I can't learn magic. I thought I could, but I can't. I got this book from Teriarch, a complete beginner's guide to spells that *should* allow me to learn every spell easily and quickly. Hell, I mastered one of the spells in the book in minutes! But I tried reading more spells before I delivered the book to Krshia and its...just not working for me.

The first two spells were easy. I learned a basic telekinesis cantrip—the ability to lift things up like Ceria and Pisces do. Nothing fancy, and I'd have to really work to lift more than the few snowflakes off the table, but it was easy enough to grasp. And then I figured out how to blow air around,

another fun trick. But then I started reading another spell—[Water Spray], a very simplistic spell that's probably Tier 0, and I got stuck.

I stare down at the page again. There are no pictures, probably because magic isn't something you can just describe in words. But I look at the meanings described on the page and I know exactly what must be done.

Let the magic condense, coalesce into a liquid, a real thing. Let it pool and grow, into a current and ocean of its own. Hold it, and then let it manifest as you push it outwards into the shape you desire. Magic is like water, a rushing thing to be guided, but never forced. You cannot force the sea to move, but you can give it a channel—

Why can't I get this? Well, because I can't believe it works. Simple as that. I understand how the spell goes and how I conjure water out of the air but—

I can't do it. It violates the basic laws of physics. To cast [Water Spray], I need to turn magic into water, anchor it in a form and then use magic to spray it out. Simple.

But I *know* that it's impossible. Magic into matter? It doesn't work like that. It violates the laws of thermodynamics! What about conservation of energy? The water dissipates fast, but does it evaporate or turn back into magic?

And what about fire? How is it mimicking a natural reaction if it's burning...magic? Would it still burn in an airtight room?

I clutch at my head. This is all wrong. It should be easy. I get how it works, but now—

I can't *believe* it works. That's the problem. All the science I know, all the laws of my reality I've grown up with—they're telling me what I'm trying to do is impossible, making me doubt what I'm doing and ask questions this book can't answer.

And magic is partly faith. It must be. If I don't believe what I'm doing will work, it won't work. And I don't believe I can cast this spell. I suppose I just didn't think about it with the [Light] spell and even when I learned to make fire. But making water out of nothing just doesn't—

The problem becomes a loop of errors in my head as I struggle to convince myself that I *can* conjure water out of nothing. But it doesn't help.

I can try to do the spell, but it won't work. I have to know. I have to understand, and I think...

"I can't do this."

Not with this book. I stare down at it, wanting to throw up, or throw it through my window. It's so easy to learn with this book. It should be. But because I went to school and studied all these damn lessons about how the world works, I can't believe in these spells.

"Education ruined magic."

I don't want to believe that's true, but I've been stuck on this one spell. I can't move on until I complete it—I just can't. Even when I look at other spells, all the doubts that popped into my head from this one follow me from page to page.

Maybe if I stare at it longer, something will click. [Water Spray]. Magic turns into water, water appears. I can't—

Damnit.

I'm so miserable and angry at myself I want to put my fist through something. A wall, maybe. I clench my fingers on my right hand and stare at the deformed fist I make.

Something else to add more depression to my day. I stare at the book and my hand.

Today wasn't a bad day. Not really. I did some deliveries. I got to see Erin punch an adventurer in the face. I saw Persua—

And the faeries think I'm boring. They left.

All except one.

I look out my window. The sky is gray and the rooftops are filled with snow. But is she out there? Or has she gone too?

She's out there. I didn't even realize it at first. But I see something hovering just outside my window. A faint blue shape, holding so still in the air that I didn't even realize she was watching me.

A Frost Faerie meets my eyes as I stare at her and nearly tumble out of my seat. She laughs at me as I stare at her and feel the wind blow into my room.

"Hello?"

She smiles at me, and floats forwards a bit. The wind is blowing hard, but she doesn't even seem to be affected by the air that blows my hair about and flicks the pages on the spellbook. She's in a little world of her own, but she stops at the edge of my windowsill.

Oh. Right. I stare at her and the room I'm in. Faeries are a bit like Vampires. They can't enter unless invited. Do I have the right? I don't own this inn—

But I am renting this room. I cough and clear my throat.

“Come in. If you want.”

The faerie stares at me for a second, and then nods in agreement. She alights on my windowsill and dances into the room, twirling and leaping onto my desk with effortless grace. Her feet leave frost on the wood wherever they touch, and I can sense the chill from her.

The faerie shivers, although I don't. She looks around the room darkly.

“Too much cold iron here. ‘Tis not a good place for true magics, or my kind. But then, ye can't even master a few tricks, so the iron doubtless hinders ye little.”

It's the first words she says. Not ‘hello’ or ‘how are you?’ or even ‘sorry I was spying on you this entire time’. She just jumps into the heart of the conversation like that. I like that about faeries.

“You mean iron interferes with spells? Is that why I can't master this one?”

The faerie shakes her head at me as she scoffs at the large tome on my table. She steps on one of the pages and kicks the parchment with a foot.

“Pshaw. The magic yon book teaches is only a fragment of true magic. Ye should know that.”

“I do. But I don't know real magic. A fragment is better than nothing.” The faerie nods, and looks at me.

“True. But you cannot learn even that, can ye? I've been watching you, and a toad would pick up that spell faster than ye can.”

I bite my tongue. But she's right.

“I can't figure it out.”

“And neither will you. You think too much and feel far too little. You look for rules where none exist, and make your own to hold you back. Ye

won't learn magic like this."

I don't want to hear that. But the faerie's words ring true. I clench my teeth again, but—she's not trying to be rude. Okay, she's doing it without much thought, but I know enough about faeries to realize she's being direct with me, and as helpful as she can.

"Thanks for the advice."

She inclines her head regally. I know I shouldn't ever thank a faerie, at least according to legend, but she doesn't seem malicious. Hell, the faeries know my full name and they haven't done anything to me.

What do they want? I clear my throat awkwardly again as the faerie looks around my little room. Here I am, with a faerie in my room. I should...she's the last one. I need to ask questions. First though, make her welcome.

"Can I offer you anything? Something to eat or drink?"

"Do ye have anything?"

"...No."

"Then don't offer, fool."

Okay, off to a bad start. I stare at the faerie as she leaps up into the air at eye height and sits there, as if there's an invisible cushion under her.

"Why are you here? By yourself, I mean. All of your friends flew off."

"They did. They grew bored of ye, and went to find excitement somewhere else."

A straightforward answer. But I still don't get why.

"Is it because of Teriarch and the game of riddles I played with him? Is that why they all left?"

"In part."

The faerie nods as she scratches at the bottom of her foot with a tiny digit. She yawns widely, showing me sharp teeth.

“My sisters think ‘twas ill done. They dislike the trickery of numbers, but it is just as good as the trickery of words to me.”

“You disagree?”

“I like such things now and then, and it was well done to win even in losing. We are not all alike, my kin. Does it surprise you that one of us would like the dance of thoughts as much as the dance of tongues?”

No. I should have known not all fairies were alike. I just—okay, maybe that was fairly racist. Speciesist? Why is it that the immortal species, Dragons and fae, tend to leave me thoughtless and speechless? It’s like all of my cynicism and complex questions fade away in their presence. There’s no doubting their presence when they’re in front of you.

The faerie points at something close to falling off the edge of my desk. The bag of holding and golden coins sits innocuously; just large enough for a handful of coins at best, certainly not large enough to hold this magical book. But it can hold a huge amount of space—all my bed covers and two chairs besides, I’ve found. After that it just acts like a normal bag until I start pulling stuff out. I haven’t yet found the courage to put my head inside.

“Yon lies your prize for a Dragon’s duel. Golden coins and a magic bag to hold them. ‘Tis every mortal’s dream, isn’t it? Or did you want something else from the old scales and smoke?”

“I don’t know. Did I?”

The faerie flies forwards and smacks me on the nose before I can blink. I yelp and touch my frozen flesh—she glares at me.

“Either you did or ye didn’t. Don’t answer a question with a question, ye prat.”

Again, I have to restrain the urge to punch back. I’d probably lose, and I know the faeries are prickly. And she’s right. Sort of.

“Sorry. I don’t know what I wanted from him. Maybe I could have asked him to teach me magic.”

“He would have said no. He’s a lazy oaf, that wyrm.”

“Maybe. But I got most of what I wanted.”

She nods, and I fall silent for a second. The real question is burning on my tongue. I have to know, so I ask it.

“Why did you stay when the others left? What do the fae really want with me? With this world?”

She looks at me archly.

“Why ask a question you know I will not answer? You want to know more than you should. You ask a question I could not answer with ten thousand words as if it were a simple thing.”

“Sue me. I’m curious. Is what I asked too broad? Why are you following me?”

The faerie sighs with exasperated patience.

“Why do I follow anyone?”

“I thought you said not to answer a question with a question.”

This time I’m ready and I swat at her as she flies at my face. The faerie flips over my hand with nimble grace and kicks my forehead. For a small creature she hits *hard*.

“Smart as an ass, aren’t ye? I follow and watch ye in case you do something of worth. You told me and my kin stories, and dared to defy the fates. You bargained with a Dragon, and met one who rules over death. Is there any other mortal I should bother following that’s done more?”

When she says it like that...I almost blush. I clear my throat. It’s so awkward, but the faerie doesn’t seem the least bit embarrassed, and that just makes me embarrassed. She doesn’t lie; she just says what she thinks.

“You’ve been following me for a while, haven’t you? I thought you were familiar—have I spoken to you specifically before?”

She nods and flashes me a smile.

“Oh yes. I followed you with the others as you ran, and I was the one you struck. I listened to tales of Humans from your world, and it was I who warned you of the armies and led you through the forest. I was there when you cast the bargain, and I accepted the second price. I am surprised you noticed; most beings cannot tell us apart.”

I thought so. For the longest time I just thought of all the faeries as one and the same, but this one—she and I have spoken more than I thought. I stare at the small faerie, and feel a sudden connection with her.

“So all of your sisters are gone because I’m too boring and you’re still sticking around. What do you want?”

“What do ye think I want?”

The faerie looks me in the eye, practically daring me to point out her evasiveness. I don’t do that this time. Instead, I think. She’s not answering me because she can’t. Or she doesn’t want to. So what’s the answer?

“Maybe...because you want something of me. Or there’s something I can do for you?”

The tiny faerie rolls her eyes.

“Hah!”

Okay, that’s not it. Then there’s something else. Or—

“Could it be you just want to see what happens next?”

“An obvious answer. I suppose ye are right.”

The faerie shakes her small head, disappointed. I feel guilty, as if I’ve failed an easy test. But what could she want?

I wish Erin were here to answer. She’d have the damn answer in a second, somehow. She’s better with people than I am. She’d be making friends with the fae in a heartbeat—she could probably befriend a rabid bear.

But then—even she’s had problems with the fae before. She told me about their scam with the fake flowers. I’m really the only person who’s

dealt with them for a long period of time. The faeries have hung around me, and I even managed to gain their respect.

And this one has followed me a long ways. Even when her friends are gone she's stuck around? Why? That's almost like...

Like...

"A friend."

The faerie looks up at me. She'd been busy spinning around in the air, but now she pauses, completely upside down and stares at me.

"What?"

"Is that what you want? A friend?"

It's a stupid question. And a stupid conclusion to make. We're not in a kid's tv show, but maybe—no.

Yes.

"Friends? Ye would be friends with the fae?"

She scoffs at me, mockingly. But the tiny fae face isn't as genuinely annoyed as normal, and I see what looks like a smile twitching around the scowl. I grin at her.

"Maybe. I wouldn't mind having one of you floating about. I know of a certain hero that did that for quite a long time."

"I'm no pet, mortal."

"No, but you are interested in me. And if you're going to follow me about, why not get to know one another?"

The faerie lies down sideways on the air and props her head on one hand as she stares at me. Seriously, this time.

"Do you know what would happen if ye dared to mingle with the fae? There are laws, mortal. Ones that shouldn't be crossed."

I hesitate. Now I feel like I'm being tested. But I can only go on what I know of her. I've seen so much of the fae, and I think I understand the answer to this question. I nod at her, just as serious as she is.

“There are consequences. I know. Dire ones. But wouldn’t a friend be willing to risk anything for another friend? I’d be honored to get to know you, if you’d let me.”

For a second the faerie’s face is blank. She stares at me from head to toe. And then she grins at me.

“Good! You finally understand a bit. You are such a fool, you, that I thought ye’d never figure it out.”

I blink at her. But the faerie flies closer, and smiles again.

“I’ve grown interested in your kind again, after so long. If you want to talk with me, I suppose a friend would be better than strangers, eh?”

I can’t believe it. But suddenly my heart is beating fast, and I feel a surge of passion and life in my chest. I feel alive again.

“I—of course. I’d be honored, as I said. My name is Ryoka Griffin, but you know that. Can I ask your name or is that wrong?”

The faerie considers this.

“My name—my truest of names—is a secret to all. And ye would not be able to pronounce it even so. But you may call me...Ivolethe.”

Ivolethe. The name rings in my ears for a second. But the faerie isn’t done. Carefully, she extends a small hand towards me. It’s such a small hand, but I extend a finger and let her shake that. For a second, the briefest second I feel coldness, the deepest chill, and at the same time a wonderful cool, a refreshing breeze and the taste of winter on my skin. It’s not at all unpleasant; I could have experienced that forever. But then the touch is gone.

But the faerie remains. Ivolethe flies back and stands on the table. I stare at her, and see her grin again. Pointed teeth, and a gaze older than the world. Her insectile wings fan out, and she begins to freeze the wood under her feet. But she’s here, and she and I are friends.

I’m friends with a faerie.

Suddenly, everything’s okay again.

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3.04

When I came down with Ivolethe on my shoulder Erin freaked out.

“Oh my god! A faerie!”

She doesn’t do subtle. As every eye turns to me I glance at Ivolethe. The small fairy is just sitting on my shoulder, looking around with keen interest.

She’s not even that cold; she’s definitely part ice, but she’s not giving me frostbite, which I think is a definite improvement. To be honest, it’s like having a miniature air conditioner on my shoulder. Not ideal in the winter, but I’d pay anything for one on a hot summer day.

“How’d she get in? Don’t cause an avalanche again! Please? It’s not even my inn!”

I have to smile as Erin tries to shield herself with a serving tray as a shield. She really, *really* can’t do subtle. I wait for someone to ask what Erin’s looking at—

Until I realize they’re still staring. Everyone. Agnes, the guests, the two barmaids—everyone. And they’re looking directly at Ivolethe.

Slowly, I look at the faerie on my shoulder. She looks like normal, but

—

“Hey Ivolethe. Can the others...see you?”

The faerie shrugs as she looks around the room.

“Perhaps. There is much iron here. Too much for a glamour.”

She looks at some of the gaping faces.

“Yes. I think they can, or they would not gape like buffoons.”

“It talks!”

Agnes exclaims in tones of ringing horror. Yep. They can hear Ivolethe, too. I stare at Erin. She stares at me.

“Wait, where are the rest of them, Ryoka?”

I look around the room. Everyone’s still staring. This is amazingly awkward.

“I’ll uh—explain in a bit. Can we get a seat, Erin? Agnes?”

That breaks the spell. In a few seconds I'm seated in the center of the room, while everyone tries to cluster around me asking questions. I hate it. I try to relocate to a corner of the room, but Erin won't hear of it and Agnes is beaming. She probably smells another attraction for the inn.

Ivolethe looks unconcerned as well. She stares up at the Humans around us, older men and women mostly, mostly married couples or travelers, and sniffs. I'll say this for her and the other faeries; they've all got the air of little queens, with the arrogance to match.

"Well? What are ye staring at?"

No one moves. Even Erin's staring with fascination at Ivolethe as she sits on my shoulder. I clear my throat.

"She's right. This is private, so if you'd all leave now?"

"Yes, begone or I will curse ye with faerie magic!"

No one moves. Ivolethe scowls. For my part, I'm at a loss. Normally my...charming disposition helps scare away even the friendliest busybody, but these people are too fascinated by her. One of them, a burly man with massive forearms, speaks.

"Is this really a Winter Sprite? Truly?"

"Yup! Doesn't she look cool? I guess faeries can't disguise themselves when they're indoors, huh?"

More confusion and looks among the other onlookers.

"Faeries? What are faeries?"

I open my mouth at the same time Erin does, but both of us pause. This world doesn't know about the fae? Even though there are actual faeries that visit regularly? Ivolethe sits up with indignation on my shoulder.

"Whelp! Ignorant fool! I am a member of the Winter Court! I demand respect!"

The man just looks at her curiously. I sense...trouble.

"They're the creatures that bring winter each year?"

"And throw snow at us from the sky?"

"And torment the animals?"

Some of the other onlookers look closer at Ivolethe. To her credit, she shows not a whit of fear. Can faeries even feel fear? When have I ever seen them even acting afraid? Oh yeah. When they were facing down a fire-breathing Dragon. Shit.

“I don’t think annoying her is a good idea.”

Erin looks scared. She told me the faeries once threw an avalanche into her old inn when Pisces bothered them. I...don’t want to see that here.

But Ivolethe appears remarkably restrained despite her clear ire. Why? My analytical side takes less than a second to give my unhappy brain a response.

Normally, any of the faeries would have thrown snow or frozen the people around us if they were this mad. But Ivolethe hasn’t done that because she can’t. Cold iron saps a faerie’s strength and makes them mortal. She can’t use her magic here.

What she can use is her mouth. So she does.

“Leave me you fool, or I will make you suffer! A faerie’s oath on it!”

That’s bad too! I open my mouth, but the big guy isn’t impressed any longer.

“You can’t do anything. You’re just like one of them Fraerlings in Baleros. Tiny.”

He cautiously pokes her where her breasts would be if she had nipples. I open my mouth and shove my chair back, but Ivolethe moves first. Her tiny mouth opens and *bites*.

The scream is immediate and loud. Ivolethe might be tiny, but she’s still big enough to take a *chunk* out of the man’s finger. Not just a chunk; she bites so far down that I see bone as he yanks his hand away. Her teeth cut through his flesh like nothing.

The man screams again as he holds up his bloody finger. Everyone, including me, stares in horror at Ivolethe. The faerie looks supremely unconcerned as she turns her head and reveals bulging cheeks. She chews, swallows, and grins at us with bloody teeth. Then she waves at Agnes, whose smile has frozen on her face.

“Innkeep! Your finest meat and drink! I am a guest here, am I not? I want service!”

The onlookers desert our table in seconds. The big man might have come back for vengeance, but Agnes drags him away with promises of a healing potion. Erin and I stare at Ivolethe as she hops off my shoulder and onto the table. After a while Erin looks at me.

“So...Ryoka. Introduce me to your friend.”

I nod. Ivolethe triumphantly leaps up as one of the barmaids comes hurrying back with some stew. Erin must have made it ahead of time, because it smells delicious. The faerie leaps *into* the bowl as if it were a hot tub and immediately begins chomping down on her immediate surroundings. I carefully move the bowl into the center of the table and clear my throat.

“This is...Ivolethe, Erin. She’s one of the Frost Faeries that’s been following me around since I met them. And she *is* my friend.”

“Right. That’s what I said.”

“No, I mean, she’s my friend. I am friends with a faerie.”

Did I say that with too much reverence? Maybe. But the words that I speak aloud are magical in their own way. A faerie. I really have one of the fae sitting in front of me, chomping down on a slice of potato the size of her head in a bowl full of soup. My friend.

“Oh my gosh.”

Erin finally gets it. She puts her hands on her cheeks in delight.

“You made a friend! Ryoka made a friend! I’m really pleased to meet you, Ivolethe! Any friend of Ryoka’s is a friend of mine. I’m sure we’ll get along great—”

“No.”

“Excuse me?”

Ivolethe doesn’t even look straight at Erin. She takes another bite of the potato and squishes it into a ball with both hands. Then dunks the potato into the gravy and scarfs the rest of it down. Her eating is both disgusting and fascinating to watch.

“I will not be your friend, Human. I have made one friend, and she is the reason I entered this place of iron and sacks of flesh. I do not need another, and if I did, it would certainly not be ye.”

Erin's face falls. I don't quite look at her, and I'm not quite smiling behind my hand. Looks like she's met someone she *can't* instantly charm. Hah!

"What? But you guys like me, right?"

"Why should I or any of my kin like a thoughtless waste of space like ye?"

"I...I made that big feast for you all! You loved it! And you paid me in gold, which turned out to be fake flowers—but you said it was a great meal! You did!"

I cough.

"I don't think Ivolethe was there, Erin. Not all the faeries stayed around your inn. Some were with me the entire time."

"Oh. But I did make food! Magical food! I even got a Skill from it!"

Ivolethe looks slightly impressed. She stops eating to study Erin from head to toe, at any rate.

"Truly? A faerie's banquet? I was not there, but my kin spoke of it. My answer remains no."

I interrupt Erin before she can try again. I'm not sure how Ivolethe would react if Erin pushed the matter—and I don't want her losing a digit.

"I'm sure Erin respects your decisions, Ivolethe. But she's my friend as well. My best Human friend. I uh, was just wondering if we could talk. Unless you're busy?"

Erin gives me a betrayed glance, but Ivolethe just shakes her head. She sinks deeper into the bowl of soup; I notice the steam has already stopped rising, and it looks like the gravy is starting to congeal thanks to Ivolethe's freezing presence.

"If I had aught to do, I would be doing it. And we are already talking, fool."

Yikes. Ivolethe may call herself my friend, but she's clearly going to be the kind of friend who uses words as barbs no matter how close we are. I

always wondered what having a friend like that would be like.

I wondered what having a true friend would be like, too. Maybe that's why I can't stop smiling. Erin's looking at both me and the faerie oddly.

"You look so creepy right now, Ryoka."

"Shut up, Erin. Ivolethe? Why can everyone see you indoors? Is it because of the iron?"

Ivolethe sits up a bit in her bowl as two more come for Erin and me, complete with soft, warm sliced bread. She stares around at the other tables, and the other guests instantly look down at their food.

"Hmf. It is the iron. Too much of it interferes with our magic. Outside it would not matter, but indoors is like a cage in a way. I cannot use my spells. But I can bite."

She grins at me again with those sharp teeth. Erin shudders.

"Interesting. But Erin and I can see you no matter if we're outside or not. Why is that?"

A tiny shrug.

"I do not know. If ye had the eyes of a cat or god—or ye were great masters of magic like Myrddin, it would make sense. But ye aren't."

Erin looks confused.

"Who's *Myrddin*?"

"Merlin, Erin."

"Oh. *Oh*. Merlin! He's real! What's he like? Does he have a cool staff? What kind of magic did he—"

I cut Erin off, although I really want to know as well. The thing about faeries is that you have to stick to one subject and keep bothering them about it. Get sidetracked and they'll lead you down a merry trail of breadcrumbs, but never get to the truth.

"We don't have that kind of magic, Ivolethe. So how else would we see you? Are there any ways mortals can see faeries?"

She shrugs again.

"Plenty. If you stood in the right place under full moon, or caught us dancing without glamor—if you had the secret drink of the fae, you would

be able to see us, but I would know if ye were taught thusly.”

“Drink? Of the fae?”

Erin looks confused...again...so I explain it to her. How does she not know any myths about faeries?

“The faerie’s drink would be given to people trusted enough to enter a faerie mound. They would be able to see the secret world with it. Could it be that?”

A rude snort.

“Hardly. Ye cannot simply make the faerie’s drink by chance. Ye would need the essence of countless gases and things not known to ye humans. Poisons and humors of foul natures beyond your ken.”

“Such as...?”

Ivolethe sighs dramatically. But there’s a wicked gleam in her eyes.

“Ye truly want to know? Then, grab as many insects as ye can, Humans! Crunch them up in your mouth, for one of the ingredients is the shell of bugs that may be used to create blood out of water.”

“Ew! You have to eat that?”

Ivolethe nods in satisfaction as Erin wrinkles her nose. But I pause. Blood out of water? That sounds like part of a riddle; probably the rhyme to the faeries’ drink they’d tell people. Blood out of water. A dye?

“When you say insects that can be used to create blood out of water... do you mean carmine? In that case, Erin and I have eaten lots of that already.”

“What? We *have*?”

Erin turns horrified eyes to me. Ivolethe looks up sharply as well. I nod.

“Carmine is a big ingredient in anything colored red, Erin. Skittles, lemonade...if you’ve had anything like that in the past, you’ve eaten ground up insect shells.”

Just a little bit, in truth. But Erin turns pale and Ivolethe looks...

“Well, there are many other things that go into the brew. Not just... that.”

“Maybe we’ve eaten all the ingredients before.”

“Really? Like *bugs*?”

“We eat countless bugs each year, Erin. They’re all ground up in our food. And companies use a lot of preservatives...”

I think out loud as Erin makes gagging sounds over her meat.

“The U.S. government started putting fluoride in the water decades ago. And we breathe in any number of pollutants that we didn’t in the past. Add that to whatever they put in most foods in the form of preservatives and to change the taste...Ivolethe, what else goes into your brew?”

“As if I’d tell you! The brew is secret to all mortals! And ye’d never guess in a million years!”

“Really? Let me just list off a few things and you let me know if I’m getting close. Sodium nitrate? Propylene glycol? Uh...what’s it called...olestra? Monosodium glutamate? Sodium benzoate?”

She glares at me.

“I do not know half of these names! You must be making them up!”

“Really? Well, sodium benzoate originally came from benzoin, a resin found on trees. It’s an ingredient in incense—”

I see Ivolethe’s eyes widen. Just for a fraction of a second, and then her head spins away.

“I-I don’t know anything about such things. This talk bores me!”

Erin and I exchange a glance. But Ivolethe’s mouth is clamped shut. Erin leans over to me, looking slightly green.

“Do you think it’s true?”

“What, that we ate all of the ingredients of the faerie brew? It might be possible. We eat a lot of weird stuff, Erin.”

“Not that! Do we really eat *bugs*?”

I sigh.

“Yes. We do, Erin. You know about all the stuff food companies put in candy and fast food. Why are you surprised?”

“I thought they were just chemicals and poisonous stuff! If I knew *bugs* were in Skittles, I’d never eat any again!”

“That’s not—why would you be okay with...? Okay, never mind Erin. Ivolethe?”

“You shall get nothing from me! I will not reveal my kind’s secrets so easily!”

The faerie sinks up to her ears in the cold soup. I raise my hands.

“I’m not going to ask you any more questions. I was just curious. Why don’t we talk about something else.”

“Yes! Let’s!”

Erin grabs her milk and drinks deeply from it. With a little coaxing, I get Ivolethe to come out of her stew. She dries herself off on a slice of bread, and then she sits on the table with Erin and me. And we talk.

“So, what did you do after I left you, Erin?”

“Oh, I just made some stuff at Octavia’s. You know, more experimental stuff.”

“Huh. Where’s Octavia now? I’ve never seen her eat—does she do it at her home or should we invite her here now and then?”

I think that would be the polite thing to do, but Erin shakes her head.

“I don’t know, but Octavia won’t want to eat today. She’s in bed with bad food poisoning.”

I pause.

“How bad?”

“*Bad.*”

“...And how did she get so sick, Erin?”

The other girl doesn’t quite meet my gaze.

“I uh, fed her something that didn’t come out as well as I’d hoped.”

“I see.”

“I would like to try it!”

“Oh no, it’s impossible. I threw it out—it was starting to stain the pot. It was just another failure.”

Erin sighs. I eye her.

“You’ve been going over to Octavia’s every day. Still trying to make new recipes?”

“Yup! I don’t want to go back to Liscor until I figure out how to make more cool stuff.”

“What about your inn?”

“What about it? Mrsha’s safe with Selys, and I don’t know where Toren is. My inn can stay where it is, right?”

“But Lyonette’s in it.”

“Oh. Yeah.”

Erin smacks her forehead lightly. I shake my head. Erin hesitates.

“She’ll probably be okay. I really want to stay here for a little while longer, though, Ryoka. I can experiment with Octavia all day, and I can help Agnes out at night!”

“And you’re not bored? You’re okay with that?”

Erin looks at me blankly.

“Yeah. Why not?”

Ivolethe and I shrug at the same time.

“Doesn’t matter to me.”

“‘Tis your choice to die of boredom.”

Erin scowls at us, but then she smiles widely at Ivolethe again.

“Soooo...Ivolethe! You must have lived a long time, right?”

The faerie eyes Erin suspiciously.

“That is obvious.”

“And you met all kinds of cool people—like Merlin and King Arthur, right?”

“Perhaps. What of it, mortal?”

Erin throws up her hands.

“Tell me stories! Tell us all about Merlin, and the knights of the round table.”

Ivolethe considers this, one tiny hand on her chin.

“No.”

“Why not?”

“I do not want to.”

“Please?”

“Erin...”

“No. Such tales are too grand for the likes of you.”

“But—”

I put a hand on Erin’s shoulder.

“You heard her, Erin. Ivolethe doesn’t want to tell, so you should respect her wishes. Besides, she probably didn’t see any of the good parts.”

“*What?*”

Ivolethe sits up in outrage. She leaps upwards and flies towards my face.

“Ye think I did not witness the legends in person?”

“Well, you don’t want to say. So I just assumed—”

“Fool! I was there when the boy became a king! I witnessed the instant the true king fell, and I have seen countless miracles besides! I saw the three kings die to each of Lugaid’s spears! How dare ye!”

“I’m just saying, you talk big, but if you’d care to share a story that you remember—”

“Hah! I will recount to you a legend beyond all else!”

Ivolethe flies into the air and raises her voice.

“Behold! I will tell you for the one true king of Camelot! His sword still sits in Avalon, waiting for his hand to draw the ancient blade! Listen well mortals!”

All heads turn as the small faerie begins to declaim. She has an amazingly loud voice, and the story—

I’m going to get to hear King Arthur’s story. I feel like a kid again. This is amazing.. Erin gives me a delighted look, and I wink at her. What can I say?

I do know a bit about faeries. Or at least, this one in particular.

The next day dawns bright and early. Or so I suppose. For once, I’m sleeping in.

So is Erin. And the rest of the guests in the inn for that matter. In fact, some are still snoring as I walk downstairs and find them lying on the tables or ground.

As it turned out, Ivoethe did know the stories of King Arthur, the entire story. The true story. And she told it to us last night, with many dramatic flourishes and a whole host of embellishments it’s true, but it was true. Every word of it. Faeries don’t lie, and to look at Ivoethe as she was speaking was to believe.

It was true. And if I were an author I would have tried to capture every word she spoke on paper. Or maybe that would have been an impossible task, because her story was one of the greats.

In the end, we just all fell asleep listening to the tragic end of the tale of the King of Knights. His kingdom in ruins, his knights dying on the field, and only the hope of his eventual return to keep spirits strong in the dark times to come. Thus, the King of Camelot closes his eyes and breathes his final breath.

And here I thought I was being smart by ripping off the poets of my age. No wonder faeries looked down on us mortals for not creating stories that can match that level. If you’ve got forever to live, your standards for good storytelling rise accordingly.

Of course, that was last night. In the light of the day, all I want is for a hot meal before I go running. But with Erin so tired, that might be asking

too much.

She has [Advanced Cooking] as a skill, but apparently you need to be at least moderately conscious to make it work. Or else not even that skill can fix dumping a bag full of flour onto an iron griddle. At least I got the pan off the fire before the flour combusted.

Mandatory near-death experience for the day completed, I finally make myself eggs and let Erin snore in the kitchen. I open the door—

And find Ivolethe waiting outside. The faerie grins at me, hovering in the crisp winter air. Honestly, I hadn't even realized she'd left when I dragged myself into my room upstairs.

"Ivolethe. How are you doing?"

"Well, mortal!"

She flies immediately to my shoulder and lands on it. Then she fidgets, and flies up to my head. I stare up at her dangling legs and sigh. But I make no comment.

As I begin to walk down the street a tiny frozen leg kicks me on the temple.

"So, what are ye doing today? More staring at books and cursing? Or will ye run about like a snail once again?"

"If you're bored, you can leave. You don't have to follow me all the time."

"Bah. I might miss something interesting. Besides, there is much to do that will amuse me in the meantime."

I shrug, but feel a bit better. I try not to smile so openly; it doesn't feel natural.

"Suit yourself."

It's a short jog to the Runner's Guild, but I pause at the door. Ivolethe senses my intentions and tenses, but she makes no move to get off my head.

"I'm going inside. Do you want to wait somewhere else?"

"I will stay right here."

“The iron won’t bother you?”

“Not overmuch. It is simply a shackle indoors, not a needle in the skin. Even if it feels so.”

Huh. I wonder how uncomfortable it is? Are faeries allergic to the metal, or is it like kryptonite?

“If you don’t want to go inside, that’s fine with me.”

“I shall stay.”

“No, I really don’t think you should go inside.”

After her last interaction with people other than Erin and me, I really have a bad feeling about letting Ivolethe inside a building. But she bends down to glare at me.

“I insist! I do not fear the iron!”

I sigh. For a being that calls herself my friend, Ivolethe doesn’t seem capable of yielding on any point. Or maybe she considers her stubbornness part of friendship.

“Just don’t cause trouble, okay? And...can I persuade you to hide in my belt pouch?”

The faerie is silent on my head for a few seconds.

“Mayhap. Is there food in the pouch?”

“Let me get some.”

That was how I found myself stuffing fried meat and sticky-sweet jam buns into a belt pouch, much to Ivolethe’s muffled delight as I walked into the Runner’s Guild. I close the pouch; Ivolethe assured me she wouldn’t suffocate inside if I did, and I’m honestly not sure if faeries breathe.

I’ve got a Frost Faerie in my belt pouch. Well, there’s that. I walk into the Runner’s Guild and stop when I see a familiar face.

“Garia!”

The broad-shouldered girl turns and gives me a big smile. But then her expression changes to one of dismay.

“Ryoka? I didn’t know you were here...today.”

I walk forwards, frowning. Garia seems nervous. And then I look over her shoulder and see a crowd of people, Street and City Runners alike, clustered around one person. She has a familiar face. Sallow, I would call it, although pinched is the more accurate word.

“Persua.”

She’s standing in the center of the room, surrounded by a huge number of people—everyone in the Guild, in fact. Even the [Receptionists] have come out from behind their counters, and an older man is standing by Persua’s side. I think...he’s the Guildmaster. I don’t know. He normally never comes out of his small office.

Persua is basking in all the attention, talking loudly in her shrill voice and laughing often. When she laughs, the others laugh with her. It’s like how she normally interacts with her posse, but now everyone’s doing it. She’s so engrossed she hasn’t noticed me yet, and from the way Garia drags me to one side of the room, maybe that’s a good thing.

“What’s going on?”

I whisper to Garia as I look back at Persua. She doesn’t look that different—new clothes and running gear maybe, but she’s just the same unpleasant person who once had my leg crushed by a wagon. My fists itch to break a few of the bones in her face.

I don’t see Fals. He’s normally in the same room as Persua, mainly because she tends to follow him about wherever possible. He’s not here today, though, and his absence is somehow conspicuous.

“Ryoka, why are you here? Didn’t you hear what was happening today?”

“No, I did not.”

I frown at Garia as I take a seat at a far table from the group. No one tells me anything. Mainly because I don’t listen if it’s an invitation to hang out or hear the latest gossip. But this...I probably should have paid attention to.

“What’s going on, Garia?”

“It’s Persua. Today’s her going-away party. She’s going to move to Invrissil, or—some other city up north. She might come back this way, but she’s not going to be around here so everyone’s having a party for her!”

Persua? Going north? Best news I’ve heard all day, and I’m barely awake still. I smile at Garia with genuine pleasure.

“What’s wrong with that? If she’s going, I’ll congratulate her as well and help her on the way out.”

Garia doesn’t grin at my response. She doesn’t like violence anyways, but she looks worried. There’s an odd emotion in her voice I can’t quite place. She lowers her voice even more.

“Ryoka...she’s going to be a *Courier*.”

“What?”

I can’t believe my ears. Persua? A Courier? She’s not nearly fast enough to be one. I should know—I saw Valceif and Hawk running, and they’re like lightning compared to *me*. Persua’s barely quick enough to be a City Runner, and she’s lazy to boot.

But Garia’s eyes are deadly serious as she nods. And I remember that moment where I swore she passed me on the road earlier—

No. It couldn’t be. Could it?

“How?”

“She leveled up and got a Skill, Ryoka! A rare one—she’s not even Level 20, I know that for a fact, but she learned a powerful movement Skill. Everyone heard about it! Ever since then, she’s been completing deliveries so fast none of us can keep up.”

A Skill. Of course. I feel a bit sick. Persua’s got terrible form, bad endurance, and she’s got no incentive to train or push herself. But give her a Skill and suddenly she can outrun anyone.

“Was it just luck? Or—how do you get Skills?”

Garia looks miserable as she shrugs. No, not just miserable. Jealous. That’s the emotion I’m seeing in her.

“Normally the good ones come up every ten levels. But you hear stories—some of it is chance, and Persua got lucky. Really lucky.”

“Okay, what skill did she get?”

“[Double Step]. It’s one of the core skills most Couriers have. That and [Quick Movement]—those were the ones Valceif had, remember? If you get those, people say you’re already two thirds of the way to becoming a Courier!”

Fuck. I remember Valceif running as if he was taking two strides for every one of mine. Garia’s right; get even one of those skills and there’s no Human from my world that could touch you. That is...completely unfair.

“Why’s she going north, then? It sounds like she could stay here and make a comfy living.”

“Well, Couriers make way more money and have more respect up north. And, Persua *has* been doing just that! She’s completed almost half of the requests in the guild by herself. They’ll have to make her a Courier soon, or we’ll all be out of work!”

I drum my fingers on the table, good mood completely forgotten. Persua the Courier. I wanted to be one, but I can’t run fast enough. Valceif told me that I might be one if I proved myself, but Persua? Before me?

It’s really, really pissing me off. But—and I have to think of the plus side here, at least she won’t be bothering me again. And if she’s taking high-level requests, maybe someone will put a hit out on her and she’ll end up dead. I can only dream.

But for now, I think I’ll get out of the way before I have to deal with Persua again. I’m about to ask Garia if she wants to join me at Erin’s new inn so I can drink the bad taste from my mouth when Garia makes frantic gestures. I don’t even have to guess to know that Persua is coming my way; it just makes sense. When I step in crap while running, oftentimes there’s a second pile waiting for my other foot*.

*Translation: When it rains it pours. Plus, Persua’s a spiteful little monster, so she’ll take any opportunity to try and piss me off.

“Why Ryoka, I didn’t see you there! Come to congratulate me on my special day, have you?”

Garia freezes, and goes pale. I stare at her, considering my next move. I don’t turn around. I don’t change my expression.

“Hello, Persua.”

“Good morning to you too, Ryoka! How *are* you today? You were gone for so long in Liscor, I thought you were dead. But you aren’t. Did you get a lot of deliveries done while you were away? Or did you just like sleeping with non-Humans that much?”

Is that an insult? I shrug. I’m not giving Persua anything, even if she’s now apparently the best Runner around.

“I had fun.”

I still refuse to look her way. Persua’s shrill voice goes up an octave as she grows frustrated. She walks around me and I catch a glimpse of her pale, sharp features and her pursed lips that compliment her sour expression.

I don’t like her. I hate her guts. But I’m also smart enough to know that she’s goading me in her hour of triumph, hoping to get me in trouble. And

you know what?

I'm not going to do a thing. It's time for the ultimate Ryoka skill: acting impassive. Guaranteed to annoy anyone with an ego.

"I'm not sure if you've heard, but I'm going to be a Courier now. Isn't that wonderful?"

The old man who's probably the Guildmaster clears his throat nervously.

"Actually Persua, that's not decided yet. You're a wonderful Runner of course, but a Courier—"

He brakes off as Persua gives him a vicious look. She turns back and gives me a big, fake smile. I just grunt.

"What do you think, Ryoka? Won't I be a wonderful Courier?"

"Mhm."

She blinks at me, and then frowns. I look slowly around and see the other Runners standing and watching us. I know some of them by face, if not name. They're City Runners, the people who band together and pat each other on the backs. They follow the leader or the fastest Runners, like Fals. Some of them are Persua's people, but most are just like Garia; afraid to cross someone like Persua.

The others are Street Runners, desperate to suck up to anyone for a bit of help, a leg up, anything. They're standing behind Persua as if they're afraid she'll blast them to ash if she gets unhappy. Garia is frozen in her seat, and I'm at the center of this maelstrom. No way out but deflection. Bring it on, Persua.

"Don't you want to say something to me? Before I go?"

"Not really."

I wish I had a drink so I could sip it calmly. I study Garia's face as Persua's fake smile turns into a frown.

"You know, I saw you yesterday. Well, I think I saw you. You were moving so slow, I thought, 'that can't be *Ryoka*'. But you were gone so fast—it's hard, being the fastest Runner around."

"I'm sure it must be."

Another scowl, covered up again. Persua might have all the abilities of a weasel, and the ability to backstab people and even orchestrate attacks, but she's not that good at concealing her emotions.

"You know, I've been taking all of the deliveries recently. I just...do them. One after another. It's so easy."

Some of the City Runners shift at that, which makes me privately happy. They don't like Persua much, and I'm sure they'll be glad to see her back. But I don't let my features change for an instant.

"Good for you."

Persua grinds her teeth audibly. I keep my hands on the table, calm, cool, collected. I'm wondering if I can get her to storm off or throw the first punch. I would enjoy that.

But she doesn't blow her lid. I see Persua pause, and then her eyes flick to the tabletop.

"I notice you've lost something. Did you leave your fingers behind on one of your runs?"

The other Runners go silent. I feel the spike of emotion in my stomach. My fingers. Garia gasps in horror as she notices them for the first time, but I refuse to react. I look at Persua coolly, meeting her evil little eyes.

"Are you going to stand around or do some deliveries, Persua? Because if you're just going to stand around talking, then do it in another corner of the room."

She blinks at me. I don't blink back. I hold her gaze; I've beaten her in a staring contest before and I'd love to humble her again. But she doesn't play my game. Instead, she smiles and looks back on me.

Crap. I shouldn't have reacted. She knows I was annoyed. No help for it.

"I'm so *sorry* if my little party is bothering you. I suppose great City Runners like you are too busy to socialize, right? Too good for us lesser Runners?"

I shrug.

"Pretty much."

Persua's face goes flat, and little pinpoints of rage appear in her eyes. She smiles at me again.

"It's just—and I know you don't mean to be rude, but you are—you haven't told me how happy you are. And I know you wouldn't want to be rude, would you?"

She wants me to congratulate her? I meet her gaze steadily.

"Come on. Don't you have anything to say?"

No. But she might go away. But no and never and not in a million years.

"Can't hear me, Ryoka? Did you lose your ears as well as those fingers?"

“I heard you. Congratulations. Piss off.”

The words pop out before I can stop them. I hear an audible *gasp* from the peanut gallery, in more than one place, and some titters of laughter as well, quickly silenced. Persua’s pale face blushes and blotches in places.

That was a mistake. I just humiliated her, and instead of backing off, she’s going to try and make an example out of me rather than lose face. I know how the routine goes. I grit my teeth and wonder how I can deal with this.

Maybe if I just walk out? But no, she’ll just call that a win or block me from leaving. And I don’t run from bullies. Let’s see what she does next.

Persua looks around, and meets the eyes of some Runners around her. Her personal posse, the ones who kissed her ass even before she learned her fancy Skill. She jerks her head and they move out from the crowd. I count them. Four—six...seven...

“That is *such* a rude thing to say, Ryoka. And on my special day as well! Here I am, Courier-to-be and you—you’re just a Runner. I think you should apologize. In fact, I insist on it.”

Oh? She’s going to get her friends to beat me down? I’m impressed; most girls wait a few months before they get that nasty. But then, this is another world and Persua’s a demon wearing crappy skin.

The other Runners step back when they see what’s about to go down. The old man tries to interject, but his voice is wavering with nerves.

“Persua, I really think—”

Her head turns and the Guildmaster goes silent. I feel a moment of sympathy for him; he’s probably not going to get much respect once she goes. Everyone’s going to remember how she walked all over him. But then I remember that he’s supposed to be in charge, and that he’s a coward. The other runners flank me, as if they’re a local mafia boss’s thugs and I’m the cringing victim.

“Well? I’m waiting for my apology.”

Persua faces me, supremely confident because she’s got a few Runners behind her. Oh come on. They don’t even have combat classes, most of them! I’m taller than all but one of the guys, and she’s seen me take down a Bronze-rank adventurer.

Okay, there are ten of them. Plus Persua. But I’ve changed a bit since we last met as well. The first day I found Erin, I had Octavia refill all of my

potions and alchemical bags. I've got two of everything ready to go, and I know several magic tricks as well.

I keep still. Not exactly a power play, but I'm not going to react to her stupid little posse.

"I'm not apologizing for anything. And if you don't get your obnoxious little cronies out of my face, they're all going to suffer."

Of all the things I know Persua was expecting, she wasn't expecting *that*. Her face goes slack, and I feel the people around me shift. Garia's looking at me as if I'm insane and trying to signal me to say I'm sorry, but I'm calm.

If they want a fight, I'm completely ready. Persua might have a Skill that makes her faster, but I'd love to see if she can dodge a pepper potion to the face. If she tries anything I'll use [Flashbang] and then hold her down while I pour the potion in her eyes. I'm just hoping she takes the bait.

She doesn't. Persua eyes me, her companions, and then decides not to risk it. She tosses her head and turns away.

"You're not even worth my time."

"Coward."

I toss the insult at her back and see it stiffen. I don't know why I said it; my mouth just won't stop in situations like this. Persua turns back, a smile full of hate on her face. We don't even try to pretend towards civility now.

"Fingerless insect. My back is all you'll see of me from now on."

"Beats looking at your face."

"How many mutts and lizards did you sleep with in Liscor?"

"Oh you know, one or two. More people than you'll ever sleep with in your life."

"I wouldn't touch one of those mongrels or scaly freaks with a stick."

"They'd just run away screaming when they saw your face."

"Whore."

"Bitch."

"You'll be stuck here forever, you pathetic, classless slug."

"And you'll never be a proper Courier in a thousand years."

We meet eyes for one last moment, and then Persua turns away. I let her walk to the other side of the room, followed by the group and don't make any move until she's laughing loudly with them and not looking at me. Then I sigh and turn back to Garia. She looks like she's swallowed her tongue.

Well, that was fun. Now I've got to warn Erin about Persua as well.
I hate my life.

"I'm out of here. Garia, do you want to join me in the Frenzied Hare? I could use a drink."

Garia starts and stammers as she looks at me.

"I uh—I—"

She doesn't want to get on Persua's bad side. Fine. I sigh and stand up. My heart is pounding fast, but I got the better of Persua in that one. No matter how hard she laughs—

I'm halfway across the smooth wood floor when I sense a blur. Persua seems to *blink* across the room, and then I feel her foot tangle with mine. She moves too fast for me to react; I trip forwards—

And catch myself, thanks to an ungainly wind milling of arms. I've been tripped before, and I've got a good stance. Nevertheless, I stumble forwards and hear Persua's mocking laughter.

"How clumsy of you. What happened, Ryoka?"

I turn and look at her. She's smirking off to one side, daring me to say something. I consider my options, and decide it's not worth it. That's her small victory; if she does it again she's dead.

I walk on, adjusting my belt pouch. Persua's still laughing, but I just make sure she didn't grab anything from me. Potions? Check. Teriarch's bag of holding? Check. Belt pouches?

One of the pouches is undone. I feel at it, and find cold, greasy meat and jam-covered crumbs in the pouch. Nothing else. My heart skips a beat. I whirl around—

"Vengeance!"

The shout springs from the tiny Frost Faerie that flies at Persua's face. The girl only has a moment to scream before Ivolethe is all over her. The faerie flies around Persua, shouting triumphantly as Persua screams and people shout in surprise.

"Take this! And suffer that, ye mortal wench!"

She rips at Persua's hair, tearing out strands and bites and scratches at Persua's face. The girl is screaming, flailing at the small creature, but

Ivolethe is everywhere. But then Persua's hand connects with the faerie by pure chance, and Ivolethe is flung to the ground.

"What is it? Kill it!"

Persua shrills as another Runner dashes forwards and scoops Ivolethe up. She yells at him and tries to bite, but he has a finger under her chin. Everyone goes silent as they see for the first time what Ivolethe is.

"What creature is this?"

"Is it—it's not a monster? A Fraerling? It's too pale! And it has wings!"

"Let her go."

I stride forwards, but Persua and her cronies immediately block my way. She stares at me, blood dripping from the scratches on her face and the places where Ivolethe yanked away skin as well as hair.

"*You* did this."

I ignore Persua and look at the Runner holding her. He's uncertain, but his grip on Ivolethe is strong and no matter how hard she struggles, she clearly can't break free. And neither is she freezing him either; she must not be able to without her magic.

"That's not a monster. That's a Frost Faerie. Let her go, now."

"A *Winter Sprite*?"

He looks at Ivorethe, stunned. She tries to move her head, but his fingernail is under her chin. She glares and dripples spit onto his thumb, but that's all she can do.

"Kill it."

Persua hisses at the other Runner. He hesitates. My heart constricts, and I raise my voice.

"Harm her, and I will kill you. My word on it."

The Runner looks back to me. He's one of Persua's flunkies, but I know my eyes are serious. I mean every word. Persua looks at me, and then at the faerie. Then she smiles evilly.

"Is this your friend? Do you have to make friends with monsters since no one else likes you?"

I ignore Persua and hold out a hand.

"Give her to me."

"Don't listen to her."

Persua interposes herself between the Runner and me. She gestures, and now her posse steps around me. I don't even look at them; my eyes are on Ivolethe.

“I’ve never seen a Winter Sprite before. Is this what they really look like? They must be the rarest of all monsters; how did you catch this one?”

I try to tune out Persua’s words. What can I do? If I grab for her, what if Ivorlethe gets hurt? How can I talk Persua down peacefully? No—it’s the Runner who’s got her. Focus on him.

But Persua blocks my view of the Runner. She looks at me, and now I see the hatred shining in her eyes, pure and simple. She turns to look at the other Runners.

“Have any of you ever heard of a Frost Faerie being captured? No? I bet that if we sold her to a [Merchant] or an [Alchemist], they’d pay hundreds, no, *thousands* of gold coins for her.”

The Runners around me shift. The mention of that kind of money changes their eyes, and some of them slowly walk over to the crowd around me.

Shit. This is bad. But I have to let Ivorlethe get free. I look past Persua and raise my voice.

“If you harm her, you will suffer for it. I don’t care how many people you’ve got; I’m not letting you take her. She’s a living being.”

“She *attacked* me!”

“So?”

Persua *hisses* with fury. She takes a step forwards, and her arm jostles the Runner holding the faerie. Instantly, Ivorlethe shouts, her voice ringing in the Guild.

“*Sisters! Sisters, hear me call and take retribution—*”

Her voice cuts off as the Runner reapplies pressure on her chin. But the damage is done. I see the other Runners looking nervous and try to capitalize on that.

“Did you hear that? She just shouted for her sisters. You’ve seen the Frost Faeries and what they do when they’re mad. What do you think will happen if you kill one of their own?”

That makes the Runners think twice. Some of them shift and edge back a bit. No one wants to suffer the vengeance of creatures that bring the winter, no matter how much they might earn.

Persua looks uneasy too, but she’s too stupid to think straight. She whirls and screeches at the Runner.

“Shut her up! Squash her already!”

“Don’t do it.”

The Runner holding Ivolethe hesitates. His hand shakes and the faerie is gasping, but he doesn’t let go. I step forwards.

“Let her go. Now.”

“You coward! Give it to me! I’ll do it!”

Persua’s patience snaps. She reaches for Ivolethe, but the Runner pulls away from her as well. I step forwards again, thinking he’s seen reason, but he raises her up. I halt, hand outstretched. Persua stares at the Runner, eyes flinty daggers.

“What are you doing?”

He licks his lips. But he’s staring at me now. He opens his mouth and croaks a word.

“Coin.”

“What?”

“You—you want her back, you’ve got to pay for her.”

I stare at him incredulously. He can’t be serious. But oh, yes, he is. He pauses again, but he holds onto Ivolethe tightly as he looks at me.

“We all know you’ve got a lot. Well—give it over. And then I’ll let her go. Otherwise—”

He squeezes a little harder and Ivolethe cries out. My blood boils, but Persua’s all smiles now.

“That’s right! Just hand over your belt pouches—and your potions—and we’ll call it even. Okay?”

Those greedy bastards. But the Runner’s eyes are serious, and Ivolethe is in pain. What should I do? If I give them Teriarch’s gold coins—but Ivolethe—

I stare at Persua. I stare at the Runner. I stare at Ivolethe, and come to a swift decision.

“Fuck it. *[Flashbang]!*”

The world and sound itself explode into confusion and chaos. I closed my eyes, but the sound wave still hits me like a physical thing. My ears ring and go silent; but I’m already charging into the Runner, body-checking him to the floor.

There’s no time for thought or anything else. I reach for his flailing hands. I have to get Ivolethe free. Get her loose. Grab his arms. Break his

bones. Bite his fingers off. I punch him repeatedly as I search for the small blue shape among the dancing spots in my vision. Where is she?

Nowhere. Gone. She's free! I see a blue shape flying towards the door, and then someone strikes me from behind.

Persua is on top of me, fingers clawing, biting, kicking. She's like a wildcat, and some of her friends try to batter me as well. I roll over, and pull out one of Octavia's potions.

The pepper potion would be better as a spray. But one good toss still gets it on a lot of faces and eyes, including Persua's. I shield my face and feel the hot liquid stinging as it reacts with my skin, but the screams are worth it. I stumble up and see Persua stumbling away from me, shrieking as she rubs at her eyes.

Something in me snaps. Her little insults, her tripping me, my crushed leg—and Ivolethe—all explode outwards in a fist that catches her on the cheek and sends her to the ground. Persua tries to get up, but I kick her down and then mount her as she flails and begin to punch.

Punch her. Hurt her. My ears are ringing, but now I hear the roaring of blood, and all that I want in this or any other world is to bash her face in. I hit and hit and hit, until something drags me back. I struggle, fighting, but whoever's holding me is too strong.

The rage hammering every inch of me subsides after a while, and I stop struggling. That's when I hear and see and think again, and realize I'm being held by two strong arms.

"Garia?"

I look around and see my friend, her nose bleeding furiously, holding me back as Persua lies on the floor. People are still shouting in pain—I see Runners clutching at their eyes and more raising their voices, deafened. Two people are with Persua, and then I see the girl herself lying on the ground.

Her face is—I only now begin to feel the pain in my hands. My fingers hurt terribly, and I feel small lacerations and bruising on my skin. I see the echoes of their impressions on Persua's face.

It's already swollen. I can barely see her features, and there's blood. A lot of blood. I broke her nose, even parts of her face. She's crying, and shaking, and the [Receptionist] holding the healing potion barely knows where to start. But as the swelling reduces a tiny bit, one of her eyes swivels towards me. And I hear her voice.

“You.”

She struggles, but the two women hold her down. Persua’s face is filled with blood and snot and tears and who knows what else. But her voice is intact. It’s a trembling mess of emotions; not a shriek, but a warbling, piercing whisper.

“I’ll kill you.”

I’m near enough to Persua that I can feel her spitting as her malformed lips form the words. Her eyes fix on me, wild, and the words pour forth, hatred in each syllable. Tears run through the blood on her face, but she still stares at me.

“I’ll kill you. I swear it. I’ll have you raped and killed. You’ll die *screaming.*”

“Ryoka—”

Garia tries to pull me back, and the [Receptionists] try to force us apart. But Persua thrashes and I refuse to move. She screams.

“*I’ll kill you! You’ll die horribly! There won’t be pieces left of you! I’ll kill you and everyone you love, you—*”

The [Receptionist] tries to jam the potion in her mouth, but Persua just spits out a broken tooth with the potion as she continues shouting at me.

There’s a crazy look in her eyes. Garia holds me back as I stare at Persua. She continues speaking, half-sobbing, half-cursing. There’s nothing I can say to her, nothing to reply with. So I just kick her in the stomach and watch her puke before Garia pulls me away.

Two hours later, I stand outside in the cold snow. I barely feel it, even though I haven’t had any of Erin’s soup. I feel the cold air blowing my clothes and don’t care.

“Ivolethe.”

The faerie hovers in the air next to me, looking uncharacteristically serious. I’m dressed up, and she’s naked. But I feel like the colder one. My heart is very cold. Very still.

I slowly sit down in the snow, and the faerie flies down next to me. The snow is wet—I don’t care. I don’t have anywhere to be, and I can’t stand. Not right now.

After a while, the faerie speaks.

“‘Twas an unexpected encounter, was it not?”

I look at her. Ivolethe looks back.

“What the hell am I supposed to say to that?”

“I am not sure. But did it end how you expected?”

I laugh, shortly.

“What do you think? I’m *banned* from that Runner’s Guild—maybe all of them right now. They might press charges, or make me pay for what’s left of the building.”

Shortly after I left, the other Frost Faeries appeared. They crashed an avalanche of snow into the building. If it hadn’t been deserted—as it was, it destroyed nearly everything inside. The last I saw, the building was so full of snow that people were having to chip away at the compacted ice.

“What a mess.”

The short version of what went down is that Persua went to the best local Healer around to get treated for the injuries the potion couldn’t fix. The Runners scattered, mostly thanks to the other Frost Faeries pelting them with shards of ice, freezing them, and so on. I think the Guild staff would have liked to hold me accountable, but when they saw the faeries literally destroy the entire Guild in one go, they had second thoughts. So did the Watch, which is how I found myself politely asked to leave the city *now* rather than be kicked out.

I probably could have stayed. But I didn’t want to be anywhere near Persua, not even in the same city. I still remember the look in her eyes.

It’s not over. I’ve never seen anyone look like that, but I know without a doubt that she meant every word she said to me. Part of me wishes I’d gone back and taken my knife and stabbed her right there and then. She’s never going to forget. But I’m not a murderer.

No matter how close I got back there.

“What a mess. What a horrible, terrible...”

The faerie looks up at me. I stare down at her. In a way, this is all her fault. Persua would have left me alone if I’d just walked on. But I can’t hate her for what she did. It’s what I’d do for Erin, the exact same.

“From now on, I’m not taking you inside ever again. Got it?”

She nods.

“That is fair.”

I shiver. Now I’m feeling the cold again, but I stay seated, cross-legged.

“I’m just glad you’re okay. If that Runner or Persua had tried—would they have killed you?”

Another nod.

“Better that you had let them. If she had slain me, her death would have followed before the next moon rose in the sky.”

Chill from within, chill without. I stare at Ivolethe.

“Who would have killed her? The other faeries?”

She shakes her tiny head.

“Not my sisters, no. There are others among the Winter Court who move in matters of death. And they are far more terrible than we.”

I don’t want to know. I don’t. Ivolethe’s face—I don’t want to know. Some things about the fae terrify me.

“It’s better that you didn’t die.”

“Perhaps. But that girl—she swore a dire oath against you. Such things can only be resolved in blood.”

“You’re probably right.”

I know she is. But I can’t think about that now. I can’t, or I’ll have to choose between killing her now or—

“She’ll be a Courier. And I won’t see her.”

“Bah. That one would give up all for vengeance. Her blades will find you no matter how far apart ye are.”

“I guess I’ve just got to outrun her, then. Although she’s faster than I am now.”

“Mm.”

We sit in silence for a while longer. I bow my head. Ivolethe just looks at the still landscape.

“I was jealous of her, you know. Just a bit. I don’t like Skills and Classes but—I’m so slow and weak without them.”

Ivolethe looks up at me silently. I avert my gaze; look at the gray horizon as I try to explain.

“It’s always the same argument. I think I’m giving away something by leveling up. Or—or I’m compromising, taking the easy route to success without any effort. But there *is* effort required, and what’s the harm in doing what everyone else is doing? It’s only logical.”

More silence. Ivolethe just listens as I externalize my struggle and confess.

“But it’s hard. I want to be strong. Erin’s—she’s stronger than me in so many ways. But I thought that would be fine. I could do things my own way, become a Courier even—I had Octavia’s potions, and I can even do magic. But it turns out I can’t even do magic that well.”

Some snow blows off of the ground and into the air. I watch it whirl upwards and away.

“I can’t do magic. And I’ve hit my limit physically. I could—try altering my body, I guess. Teriarch mentioned that. But that’s cheating too. I just wish there was a way to be faster. Just faster. If I were faster, I’d be happy with the rest.”

“So what is it ye wish?”

Ivolethe turns to face me in the snow. I look down at her, and feel that same sense of envy.

“I wish I was better. Just...better.”

“‘Tis a tall wish. Even a King could not grant your request. Why not be content with your self as it is now? You are brave and quick; is there aught else you need?”

I know she’s right, but at the same time, she’s wrong. I shake my head and shiver.

“Who I am isn’t enough. I want to become more. Is that too much to ask?”

For a while Ivolethe studies me. Then she smiles, teeth flashing in the winter sunlight.

“It is. But mortals have always wished for such. That is why you spread like wildfire while we remain, timeless.”

She looks rueful and sad, and happy at the same time, like an adult watching a child play. My heart aches.

“I don’t know what to do. What would you do, in my place, Ivolethe?”
She looks at me from head to toe.

“What is it you’ve dreamed of, Ryoka Griffin? What do you wish for with all your heart?”

It’s an important question, but I know the answer in a second. I just have to think back to the day I started running. I speak my reply to her and the cold.

“I always wanted to run like the wind. I felt it once, when you led me and Mrsha away from the Goblin army.”

I remember the rushing air behind me, and the sense of weightlessness I felt. Each step was forever, and I watched the world fly past me. For a second I was wind, and I lived my dream.

“Well then, I would search for that. I would seek to run as the wind, for that is my dream. If I did not chase such things, I would not be mortal, no?”

“How?”

I have to laugh.

“Even a Courier couldn’t run like that. At least, not Val or Hawk. And certainly not without levels. How would I ever get that fast, when I can’t even outrun *Persua*?”

Ivolethe spreads two tiny hands.

“We are friends, are we not? What do friends do but help each other?”

She grins at me again, and I pause.
“What? How could you help?”

“You want to study magic? To become better? I told you once; you will not find what you look for in a book. But perhaps it is because ye haven’t seen what magic truly is.”

I know what she’s hinting at. But I have to hear it out loud.
“What are you suggesting?”

Slowly, Ivolethe flies upwards until she sits in the air in front of me. She looks me in the eye, still smiling.

“I’ll teach you the ways of the fae, not the tricks mortals use. I will teach you to listen to the wind and run like we do. That is what a friend does for a poor mortal who wishes to be better than she is.”

My heart is thundering. My breath catches in my throat.
“Can you do that? Isn’t it against the rules?”

“No one has made rules against this. No one has been mad enough to try. But for you, friend, I would try. It’s worth a shot, eh?”

I look at her. Ivolethe grins at me, a tiny, mad faerie. My friend. I stare back at her, a shivering, depressed Human girl who dreams of flying. Slowly, I offer her a hand.

“If you’d be crazy enough to try it, I’d be forever in your debt.”
Ivolethe wrinkles her face in disgust and slaps away my hand.

“Bah. Do not make such promises so lightly. Nae, I offer you this: I will try to teach you to run like the wind for one thing.”

“Name it.”

“Friendship.”

She offers me a tiny hand. I don’t hesitate. I reach out, and her grip is like melting ice, winter’s thaw, the moment of tiny warmth in the frozen

heart of the world. We shake, and it is done.

A faerie's bargain. A friend's promise. A child's dream.

The wind blows, and my heart races off with it.

To run like the wind.

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3.05 L

The day after Ryoka's encounter with Persua and the day before everything else happened, a [Message] was sent to Celum addressed to Ryoka and Erin. Two spells, actually. They were duly recorded and when Ryoka remembered to stop by the Mage's Guild, they were delivered to both girls at the counter with no incident.

Erin and Ryoka stared at the short piece of paper and the neat, clearly legible handwriting of the scribe. It was a short message, but hit all the points Erin had been privately worrying about.

Erin, Mrsha is with me and Olesm is keeping an eye on your inn. M is worried, but adjusting. All is well; do not get stabbed by Goblins. I have told Klbksctch and Relc. Stay safe,
–Selys.

Erin breathed a sigh of relief as she looked at the message while Ryoka looked at the short reply she'd received from Krshia.

We will await the delivery. The others will abide until then.

The other girl didn't exactly sigh in relief, but it put her mind at ease. Both young women left the Mage's Guild without sending a return message, and met with Ivolethe and Garia to go about the rest of their day. While the situation was not ideal, Erin and Ryoka agreed that things would keep a little while before they would need to return.

However, all those in both Celum and Liscor had omitted one person in their exchange of messages. Selys had completely forgotten about her while attempting to deal with a restless and upset Mrsha, and Krshia was too busy taking care of her nephew Brunkr, who was lying in bed moaning about his paw. Erin was too busy thinking about Toren to remember, and Ryoka didn't really care. Thus, no one had mentioned the last small detail left unresolved in Erin's inn.

They had all completely forgotten about Lyonette.

Lyonette sat in the empty inn that belonged to Erin Solstice and stared at the shuttered windows. It was dark. The room was empty and quiet and the falling snow outside did not disturb the suffocating *stillness* of the building. Nevertheless, Lyonette stayed still, refusing to move. She was not crying, and she wasn't having hysterics. She was above such common reactions.

But she was afraid. She could see snow falling between one of the cracks in the shutters. It was the only one not fully covering the glass windows. She knew she should get up and close it fully, but she didn't want to. Fear held her down.

Lyonette, or Lyon as she now grudgingly answered to, watched the snow slowly build up outside. Flakes fell down from the overcast sky, disappearing into the blank landscape. She watched the snow fall and wondered when it would stop. Part of her wanted it never to stop, as if time was tied to the snow. So long as it fell, time wouldn't pass and she wouldn't have to confront the truth.

Erin Solstice was gone. She had left her inn one day and never come back. She was gone, and now so was the cute little Gnoll child named Mrsha. Ryoka Griffin, the surly Runner girl had left too, and all the guests had stopped arriving. Now the inn was deserted, save for Lyonette. And if the Goblins came back, she would just be a corpse. Or worse.

In the growing cold, Lyonette shivered. She hadn't dared light a fire, even though the winter chill meant she had bundled herself in every article of clothing Erin had given her. She had even dragged a blanket downstairs and she was shivering in it. She could see her breath sometimes in the air—if she held her breath and then slowly breathed out, she could see it as a small vapor trail.

This was a new discovery for Lyonette. She had seldom been in any place where she was this cold for this long. She had always been taken care of by a bevy of servants; exposure to potentially lethal cold like this was unthinkable.

But her servants were on another continent and Lyonette was alone. And Erin, the only person who had taken care of her, was gone. She might have been killed by the Goblin army. They had gone north, hadn't they?

At that thought Lyonette shuddered uncontrollably and nearly fell out of her chair. The Goblin army. They had come through Liscor's path, a huge

army of them, just like those led by the Goblin Lords of the past. She hadn't seen anything like a Goblin Lord, but the army had been enough to give her waking nightmares.

She remembered that night vividly. She had been sleeping in her bed the day after Selys had taken Mrsha. Lyonette hadn't been sleeping well; she'd barely gotten to bed after the female drake had finally dragged the Gnoll forcibly out of the inn, ignoring the *howls* and shrieks of distress the Gnoll cub had made. And then she had heard the high-pitched shouting, and woken from her slumber. A minute later Lyonette had realized it wasn't shouting she was hearing, but the Goblins.

An army had marched out of the darkness, through the falling snow, hundreds, thousands of them. Some had been holding torches, but the vast mass of their number had been mostly shadows, rapidly traversing the deep snow, laughing and *shrieking* as the torchlight glinted off of metal.

A Goblin army. The bane of civilization. Lyonette had been too afraid to count and see if there were really hundreds of thousands of them like those that had marched in the last Goblin King's army. The instant she had realized the Goblins were moving towards Liscor, she had barricaded the door and fled upstairs to her room.

Lyon had hid in her room on the second floor of the inn, hiding under the bed with her heart hammering out of her chest as she heard the Goblin host marching past. Her first thought had been that the Goblins were attacking Liscor. But they hadn't. Instead, the Goblin army had moved around the city on the eastern side. They were headed north, to the Human lands, and that had forced them to bypass Liscor.

The Goblins had passed by the walls of the city in one mass, loosing arrows up at the defenders while the [Guardsmen] held their ground behind the battlements. A few volleys had been loosed in return, but the main deterrent had come in the form of a glowing orb of crackling lightning that had formed over the southern wall. It had sent bolts of lightning shooting down towards the Goblins, who had scattered and retreated to a safer distance.

Lyonette had recognized the wards of course. They were standard among most large cities that faced regular monster attacks. And they were a sufficient deterrent for the Goblin army, for the mass of monsters didn't stop to retaliate again and disappeared down the northern road. Lyonette had watched the dark shapes vanish and waited even longer until the last

eerie howls had been covered up by silence. But she had hid in the inn until the morning, and many hours after that.

After that—silence. Lyonette had stayed in the inn for two more days, only opening the door once when a strange Drake she vaguely recognized tried to enter. He hadn't said much—his name was Okresm or something and he had left as soon as he realized Lyon was still living here. Rather, she had chased him out.

Now Lyonette was regretting that, however slightly. It had been days since the Goblin army had passed, and the young woman had heard nothing about Erin's whereabouts. For all intents and purposes, she had vanished.

What had happened? Ryoka had left with a few curt words saying she was going to look for Erin. Then Selys had decided to take Mrsha into the city and they'd gone. And then—

Nothing. Where was Erin? Had Ryoka found her, or was she still looking? Lyonette was in the dark about everything, and with only her fears to speak to her day after day, her paranoia had mounted.

Erin was never coming back. She might be, but she could be hurt, or wounded. What if a monster had killed her, or her skeleton? Maybe it had shown its true colors and stabbed her when her back was turned, or simply abandoned Erin in the middle of nowhere. She could be dead! Or eaten! Or

Lyonette imagined Goblins doing all the horrible things her [Governess] had told her about, or what she'd heard when eavesdropping on the palace staff. Erin might have run into the Goblin army. She could be dying right this instant.

That didn't inspire Lyon to go out searching for Erin like that rude Ryoka had done of course. She wouldn't know where to begin, and the Goblins had probably eaten her. Besides, Lyon didn't owe her anything. Erin Solstice was a rude peasant who treated no one with respect and was too trusting for her own good. Anything that befell her was probably her own fault.

But Lyonette had to admit, the inn had never seemed so dark when Erin Solstice was around. And it had never been quite so...

Empty.

It was as if the life of the inn itself had gone with Erin. The day after she'd left, all the guests had stopped arriving. That may have had to do with the Goblins and the lack of any lights in the windows—Lyonette had

stopped lighting the fire in the common room of the inn—but in an instant, the bustle of the building had ceased completely.

At first Lyonette had been impatient, waiting for Erin's return. Then she had been afraid. Now, after many days, she was just...quiet. Lyonette sat in the inn day after day, only leaving now and then to fetch some water to drink or use the outhouse. But the longer she sat in the dead building, the more she knew something had to change.

It wasn't a quick realization. If anything, it was a thought born out of several nights of sleeping with her back to the door, wide-eyed, flinching at any random sound in the night. It was finding Erin's little money stash and realizing most of her gold coins had been given away to the Horns of Hammerad or on Erin's person when she disappeared. It was staring at the empty pantry and feeling the small hole in her stomach where food should and always had been.

Lyonette had cried herself to sleep the first night she'd gone to sleep with her belly writhing with hunger; the next she'd just slept, too exhausted to even weep. Six days after Erin had vanished, Lyonette knew what had to be done. She looked up and watched another wisp of warmth vanish into the dark room of The Wandering Inn. She knew.

Erin Solstice wasn't coming back. Or if she was, it might be tomorrow, a week from now, or months. Either way, if she was gone for even a little while longer, it would be too late. So. Lyonette knew what had to be done while Erin was gone.

She had to work. Or she would starve.

It was a foreign concept to Lyon in many ways, a hateful one. Demeaning. But it didn't change the facts. She was running out of Erin's coin, and she had even less food in the building. She had to work. Erin's inn had sustained itself by selling food to customers; she had to continue that.

There were no other options Lyonette could think of. She couldn't envision herself making her way north through the snow, and the Goblins—no. And she was banned from the city, so that left only the inn.

Again, this wasn't a conclusion Lyonette came to willingly, but after two days of eating the last crumbs of frozen cheese and equally hard bread that was the last of the food in the pantry, Lyonette was desperate. That was how she found herself waiting at the door when Olesm, the Drake, cautiously broke his way through the snow to her inn.

"You! You there, Drake!"

He nearly jumped out of his scales when Lyonette threw the door open. She had seen the Drake come by the inn every day, or every other day at the latest. He usually just peered hopefully through one of the windows for a few minutes before leaving, usually quicker if he saw her face.

“Oh. It’s you. Um, Lyon, wasn’t it?”

Lyonette gave the Drake a big smile and deliberately refrained from correcting him on her proper name.

“That is right. And you are...Olesm, correct?”

“That’s right.”

The Drake coughed and looked into the dark inn hopefully.

“Is uh, Erin not back yet?”

“No. She hasn’t returned.”

“Ah. I see.”

The Drake hesitated.

“Well, I won’t be getting in your way. I’ll ah, drop by tomorrow, then.”

“No! Don’t do that! I mean—why don’t you stay here?”

“What?”

Lyonette opened the door a bit wider. The Drake blinked into the dark room, and Lyonette realized that he probably couldn’t even see inside.

“It’s a bit dark, but I’ll start the fire. You can stay and—and order something!”

The Drake looked doubtfully at Lyonette as she smiled desperately at him.

“But Erin isn’t here right now. She’s the innkeeper.”

“Yes, but *I’m* still here, aren’t I?”

“I guess you are.”

“Well then. Why not come in? Erin’s inn—is still her inn even without her, isn’t it?”

“That might be true?”

Olesm frowned. He looked backwards towards the city as if he was considering leaving, then he reluctantly shrugged.

“I guess I could stay for a bit...”

“Good!”

Lyonette nearly gasped with relief. She opened the door and the Drake stepped in. He shivered; the inside of the inn was scarcely warmer than the outside.

“It’s *freezing* in here! Why isn’t the fire on?”

“I...forgot.”

Lyonette pretended to fuss with some kindling in the fireplace. Then she struck some sparks with the flint and steel and the fire flickered into life. Olesm watched the small flames consume the shaved wood and begin to eat away at the larger sticks Lyonette had arranged in the fireplace as he stared around the empty building.

“It’s so dark. And gloomy. Uh, not that that’s a bad thing. I guess when Erin’s not here...”

He cleared his throat.

“Did—did you say you had something to eat? I wouldn’t mind a snack.”

“Food? Oh, now that you mention it—”

Lyonette turned as casually as possible and gave Olesm her best contrite expression.

“I’m sorry, but I forgot—there’s nothing left in the pantry. With Erin gone, there’s no one to go shopping.”

“Not you?”

The Drake frowned at Lyon. She hesitated.

“I can’t go into the city. I’m banned.”

“Oh yeah. Right. You’re the thief.”

“I—”

Lyonette hesitated. Then she slowly closed her mouth. She was the thief, even if she didn’t have the [Thief] class. She hadn’t seen herself as one, but the Drakes and Gnolls thought of her that way. She had to humor him.

“I am. That is right.”

She tried to look apologetic as possible.

“It’s all my fault, of course. I would go shopping, but I can’t. So there’s nothing to eat here.”

“Ah.”

The Drake just stared at Lyonette. She cleared her throat again.

“I don’t know what I’ll do without food. If I can’t serve people, how will I keep the inn open until Erin gets back?”

“You? You’re going to keep The Wandering Inn open?”

The look Olesm gave Lyon was full of disbelief. She gritted her teeth, but nodded.

“It’s my job. I *am* a [Barmaid] after all. And I’m Erin Solstice’s employee. She said so herself. And what sort of...help would I be if I didn’t

keep her inn open and earn her money while she was gone?”

“I suppose that makes sense.”

Olesm frowned as he scratched at his chin. Lyonette nodded, the desperate smile still fixed on her face.

“So I need someone to help deliver food to the inn while Erin’s gone. I’ll pay of course—and you can eat here as well!”

“Wait, what? You want *me* to bring you food?”

The Drake sat up in his chair and frowned hard at Lyonette. She nodded, keeping her eyes on him.

“You have to. Not cooked food; I’ll sell food here like Erin did. But you have to bring the supplies here so I can cook it. Or else I’ll starve. And you wouldn’t want that, would you?”

The Drake gave Lyonette a look that wasn’t quite as reassuring as she’d hoped. But he eventually agreed to find a way to get Lyonette more food.

“I guess I can make a few trips—but how will you keep the inn open? Without Erin, doesn’t this place lose a lot of its ah, attraction? Why would anyone come this far?”

“Why, because I’ll cook fine food of course, and serve people with grace and decorum!”

“Really? You?”

Olesm looked completely unconvinced. Lyonette ground her teeth, but she smiled at him.

“I *do* have a Skill in cooking.”

“You do?”

“Absolutely. And I’ve waited tables for nearly a month. You just bring the ingredients, and I’ll cook it. In fact, why don’t you bring some right now? I have money and a list right here...”

“Well, it’s sort of cold out—you mean now? What about—”

Olesm blinked as Lyonette thrust a sheet of parchment and some coins into his claws and practically pushed him out the door. She stared anxiously at him in the snow as he stared at the inn, and then watched him trudge slowly down towards the city, heart pounding all the while.

She’d done it! But the real test would be if he came back. Lyonette stared out the window at the faint shape of Olesm as he walked into the city, and then she sat at the window as the air in the room slowly warmed, staring fixedly at the gates.

It felt like forever and a half before she saw a burdened figure leave the city and start walking her way. It felt like even longer before the Drake struggled up the hill and exhaustedly dropped the packs full of ingredients on the doorstep as Lyonette flung open the door.

“Thank you so much for bringing everything here!”

“What? It was nothing. I mean, it was a bit heavy—I don’t suppose you have anything to drink?”

“I have to cook first.”

Lyonette was already busy opening the ties on the pack. Olesm nodded as he sagged into a chair.

“In that case, I could definitely use a bite to eat. Something hot.”

“Oh. Now?”

The Human girl stared at the Drake. He stared back.

“Yes. I mean, you *are* going to make food, right?”

“Of course. But—”

Lyonette hesitated.

“—I have to work on a few recipes first. Why don’t you come back two days from now? Then I’ll probably need some more ingredients. Or—you could return tonight if you want to buy something.”

The Drake looked indignantly at the bulging pack of supplies he’d brought.

“What? My meal’s not on the house?”

“No!”

Lyon glared at him. The Drake glared back.

“Okay, I guess I’ll come back later. I mean, if you’re not busy.”

“You do that. And remember, I’ll need more food soon! And tell your... friends. The Wandering Inn is open again!”

Lyon barely heard the door slam as Olesm walked out. She was too busy staring at the wonderful contents of the pack. Eggs, carefully wrapped to avoid breaking, fresh cheese—flour—her stomach growled uncontrollably and Lyonette’s hands shook.

Half of her wanted to scarf down everything raw, but she made herself drag everything into the kitchen and put all the ingredients away first. She had to do this right.

Almost mechanically, the girl pulled out ingredients and set them on the counter as the fire she’d started in the kitchen began to warm the air here too. She blew on her hands, ignoring her empty stomach as she prepared

herself. She was going to cook. She, Lyonette du Marquis, was about to make a meal.

Hot shame and burning desire stole over her in waves, but the emptiness in her stomach quashed all other feelings. Lyonette stared at the ingredients and imagined something basic. Pasta. She remembered the lovely, buttery noodles Erin had served to her and the other guests in the inn one night. She could do that, surely?

Lyon had [Basic Cooking] as a Skill now, a fact that filled her with shame and privately elated her. It was the skill of a peasant, yes, but it was *her* Skill. It was hers.

That was how she found herself cooking with the flour, salt, eggs, and some water in the kitchen. Lyonette first mixed flour and salt together, and then made a divot in the mound of powder to add a beaten egg. Then she mixed in a beaten egg and squished the sticky mess together until it began to congeal. As if by magic, the disgusting mess of egg and flour became a different substance. Dough!

It was dough, the very thing Lyonette had seen bakers turn into golden loaves of bread! She stared at the small ball sitting on the counter of the kitchen and stared at her flour-covered hands in amazement.

“That’s how it’s done? It’s so...easy!”

She’d expected there to be some laborious process required, or a convoluted mix of ingredients. But this? Barely a few minutes of effort and she was nearly finished with her cooking! Part of Lyon was elated, the rest indignant that people paid [Bakers] and [Cooks] so much. There was nothing to it!

But Lyonette quickly realized she wasn’t done as her Skill prompted her to keep going. She had to knead the dough for several minutes, until Lyonette’s weak hands were cramping up a bit from the effort. Then, she had to find the rolling pin in one of the drawers and smooth out the dough. And then Lyon had to cut the dough into long strips, and then boil water.

That was actually the hardest part. Lyonette had of course gone to fetch water many times in the past for Erin, but she’d hated the duty and had done it as slowly as possible. Since she was making food for herself and she was alone, Lyonette had no excuse. She had to make two trips for water, and she was exhausted by the time she watched the water boil over the fire.

Then, Lyonette added the pasta and a bit of salt and watched the noodles swirl around as she stirred the pot anxiously. After only two minutes the

pasta was done. Lyonette dumped the water outside and scooped the rest out of the pot, shaking it to dry the last of the water. Then she put it in one heaping mound on her plate and dug in.

In the lukewarm inn, by the flickering fire, the young [Princess] used a slightly-bent fork to lever the first mound of noodles into her mouth with a shaking hand. She bit, chewed, and swallowed, scarfing down the food almost too quickly to taste it. But she tasted the second bite, and the third, and her face fell with each new forkful of her pasta.

It couldn't be. But it was. As the aching feeling in her stomach subsided, Lyonette slowly chewed the slightly watery noodles and knew the truth. Her food wasn't great. It wasn't even good. It was bland. No, worse, it was simply mediocre. True, she'd made noodles thanks to her skill, but they were a far cry from what Erin could now do.

Lyonette had been famished, but even she couldn't finish the huge mound on her plate. After about two thirds of it she just sat back and stared at the pale mass of noodles, disgusted and disappointed in equal parts.

It wasn't the same at all. She could remember the wonderful noodles Erin had made not so long ago—buttery and hot, and delightfully fragrant thanks to some herb. It had been delicious even without the meatballs. Lyonette's mouth watered just remembering.

But this? This was just pasta, barely serviceable. It was a disgrace to any inn, and worse, it had come from a Skill. Lyonette's Skill. Was this all she could do, even with [Basic Cooking]?

Lyonette wanted to cry again. This wasn't *fair*. Why was her cooking this bad? She'd remembered ordering one of her [Maids] who had [Basic Cooking] to make her a snack, and while it hadn't been great, it hadn't been...this. What had she done wrong?

Then she remembered what one of her tutors had said on the rare days she'd been paying attention. Skills could improve one's ability greatly and even give them the means to do things they would never be able to do normally, like fish, work metal, or even fight. But a Skill improved on what was already there.

If two [Warriors] with the same Skills fought, the one who had trained longer and had more actual combat experience would inevitably prevail. Similarly, even with [Basic Cooking], if Lyonette had never made food, all her cooking would be just that: basic.

For two minutes Lyonette just stared at the cold plate of noodles, and then she heard a knock at the door. Instantly her body went rigid with fear and apprehension, but Goblins wouldn't knock, would they? This wasn't a monster, this was a guest. A guest!

She scrambled to her feet and flung the door open. Her mind was racing—was it too cold inside? She should have opened the windows to let everyone know the inn was open tonight! What about cooking? She couldn't serve food to—what should she say? What was it that Erin had always told her to say to new customers? 'Welcome, please have a seat?' or was it, 'let me take your coat'?

The person standing in the doorway as Lyonette yanked the door open had no coat to take. A massive drake—far bigger than Olesm—blinked down at Lyonette as she stared up at him. After a moment, he coughed.

"Hey...you."

"Um, welc—do you have a seat for your coat?"

"What?"

Lyonette turned red. The Drake scratched awkwardly at the spines on the back of his head and looked past the young woman into the inn. His eyes noted the single plate and dim fire before they returned to her.

"Is Erin back yet?"

Lyonette gulped. She vaguely recognized the Drake; he was Relc, the one Erin had thrown out of the inn earlier. But he was also a guest, wasn't he? She tried to smile as welcomingly as possible as she opened the door a bit wider.

"Not yet. But would you like to stay and have something to ea—"

"Nope. See ya."

The Drake turned before Lyonette had even finished her sentence. Desperately, she threw the door open to call out to him, but her breath caught in her chest when she saw the black Antinium standing next to the Drake in the snow. He'd been so still, so silent, she hadn't even seen him at first.

Klbbkch stared at Lyonette for a second and then turned to walk away with the Drake. Lyonette stood in the doorway, at the backs of the two [Guardsmen]. They waited until they were a few paces away from the inn to start speaking, but the wind blew their voices up the hill towards her.

"Looks like Erin's not back yet."

"Indeed."

“But who was that Human? I’ve never seen her before, have you?”

“I believe it was the thief that Erin Solstice employed.”

“Who?”

“The one who burned down Miss Krshia’s shop, I believe. The one exiled from the city.”

“Who?”

“The Human girl.”

“There are a lot of—”

“The one who called you ‘scaley oaf’.”

“Oh! *Her*. Hey, can I go back inside and beat her up a bit?”

Lyonette shrank back in the doorway, but the other voice stopped the first.

“That would not be wise. If Erin Solstice comes back and finds you have attacked her staff, she will most likely ban you for life.”

“Damn. Are you sure?”

“Very. You will have to give her your apology gift later. Although, you will first have to buy her a gift.”

“Hrgh. I know, I know. But what do Human females like, anyways? Should I get her some meat? Jewels? I don’t have that much money on me, you know.”

“I recommend we ask about. There are Humans in the city. Let us ask them.”

“Sure, I guess. If we have to. Hey, where should we eat tonight...?”

The voices trailed off as the wind changed directions. Lyonette shivered as she stood in the open doorway a moment longer, staring out into the dark snow. Then she closed the door. She felt...bad, even though she didn’t know why. But the inn was full of light, especially when she opened the windows and added more fuel to the fire. It was warm and bright and it almost felt like before, even if dinner had been bland. But it wasn’t the same.

It really wasn’t.

Someone else came by that night. Lyonette was in the kitchen, trying to work out what would make the pasta taste better when she heard the door open. She hurried into the common room and saw a man wearing a worn,

serviceable dark cloak shaking snow off of it as he looked around. A dagger at his side was his only weapon, but he walked as if he only needed his piercing glare to kill anything that might accost him.

Lyon recognized him as well. The man looked as annoyed as ever, and perhaps even more so today. His expression was grim, and he reminded Lyon of the oldest and grumpiest of the kingdom's soldiers. She knew who he was—a Gold-rank adventurer. That made her defer to him slightly, even though she was royalty. It was certainly not because she was afraid of him. Well, maybe a little.

“W-welcome sir! Miss Solstice isn't back yet, but if you'd like to stay, I could make you some pasta—”

Halrac's piercing gaze froze Lyon in place. He looked at her, and then around the inn. He shook his head and grunted irritably.

“Hmph.”

He turned and left without another word. Lyonette watched him leave through one of the windows as the adventurer stomped back towards the city through the snow. She didn't know what to think about that, but she imagined how much money a Gold-rank adventurer might have spent and felt even worse.

All in all, it was almost a relief when Olesm dropped by. The Drake was still irritable, but he came by for dinner by himself. He grew much more cheerful when Lyonette served him pasta and told him he wouldn't have to pay for it; his expression immediately changed when he bit into the over-salted batch she'd made this time. He ate four bites and then pushed his plate away and didn't touch it for the remainder of the time he spent in the inn.

Not that he took that long anyways. Olesm only stayed long enough to tell Lyonette about the Goblin army's sacking of Esthelm, the news that Erin was alive in Celum, and that she wasn't coming back any time soon. She badgered him with questions, but the Drake had no answers.

“I don't know when she can come back, okay?”

He snapped at her as he drank some of the hot water she'd boiled and grimaced at the taste. It was the same water she'd used for the noodles, and he pushed that back on the table as well after another sip.

“But—when will she return? Can she?”

Lyonette wrung her hands. Olesm just shrugged, looking unhappy.

“It’s dangerous on the roads, and frankly, it might be safer where she is. After everyone’s [Dangersense] got triggered in the city, Zevara’s put the entrance to the dungeon on permanent watch with every spare [Guardsmen] she can muster.”

“The dungeon?”

Lyonette had no [Dangersense]; she hadn’t even realized the entrance to the dungeon had been uncovered. Olesm nodded as he exclaimed.

“None of the adventurers want to go in. Griffon Hunt hasn’t even gone through the entrance yet, and all the other groups are staying put. No one’s sure what will come out—if anything. Someone’s got to go in, but until one of the groups works up the nerve, it’s another threat along with those Goblins that the city has to be wary of.”

He sighed and stood up. Lyonette watched him anxiously. Olesm looked at the food and water and shook his head briefly before digging in his pocket.

“Here.”

He put a few bronze coins on the table and nodded to them.

“For the food. I’m not that hungry, I guess.”

“You’re going? Already?”

Lyonette was surprised at the tone of her own voice. Normally she would have welcomed silence, but Olesm was the first person to even enter the inn since Erin had left. The Drake nodded, looking tired.

“I’ve got to plan some stuff out with Zevara and—well, I’m busy. I’ll stop by tomorrow, though.”

“But why not stay here? For a little while longer, I mean?”

Olesm paused, looking awkward.

“I’ve really got to be going. I still need to eat—I mean, I’ve got a lot...”

He stopped and stared at something in the corner of the room.

Lyonette’s eyes were drawn to the ghostly chessboard on one of the tables. None of the pieces had moved since Erin had left, but the Drake’s eyes fixed on them for a few seconds. He looked back at Lyonette.

“You wouldn’t happen to play chess, would you?”

Lyon shook her head reluctantly. She remembered it being the latest trend in court, but she’d never picked up the game. Olesm looked disappointed.

“Oh.”

He left soon after, despite Lyonette's attempts to entice him to stay. Afterwards, Lyonette stared at the bad pasta and hurled it into the fire along with the plate. It made a horrible mess and stunk terribly as the fire consumed the pasta. Then Lyon just stood in the center of the room as the smell of burnt food filled the inn.

She was lost. For a few minutes Lyonette desperately tried to suppress her tears, but then they came forth and she just stood in the empty inn, letting them roll down her cheeks and drip onto the floor.

It was all over. She couldn't do it. She couldn't cook, and no one liked her. Lyonette had known that—she'd even relished the knowledge before. But now, she knew it would be her death. No one would buy any food. She'd starve to death and Erin would find her bones in the inn when she came back.

She was a failure. That's all she was and would ever be. The pitiful third daughter of a small kingdom, dying alone in an inn that wasn't hers. She was nothing.

The girl curled up on the floor as the embers of the fire glowed and faded. She stopped crying because even that was no use, and lay there, waiting to die. She grew still as she rolled herself up into a ball of misery. Then the door opened, and the Antinium walked in.

Pawn didn't know why he went to The Wandering Inn. It was just where his feet carried him. The Antinium had no idea what to do or where to go; he just knew that he might find the answers he sought if he could listen to a certain young woman for a while.

It had been a long time since he'd gone there. In fact, this morning he'd intended nothing of the kind. Pawn had woken up sitting in his small sleeping spot and believed today would be like all the rest. Empty and uncertain.

The Antinium do not lie down to sleep. It's not that they can't, but their backs do not curve like mammals. Pawn's own back resembled a beetle's in many ways, and he disliked the rocking that occurred when he tried to lie down. Thus, both Workers and Soldiers alike slept while sitting. It was the most economic use of space, and in the huge barrack-like sleeping area that held five hundred Workers, Pawn had had an adequate six hours of rest.

That was how Pawn's day began. He would pull himself out of his small cubicle of dirt with his four arms and file into line with the other Workers as they left the room at the same time to receive their morning nutrition.

It was easier for Pawn to do this today than it had a few weeks ago. He had regrown all but a few digits on his hands, and his severed limbs had nearly fully regenerated thanks to the unique healing substances the Antinium used. As he stood behind a Worker, Pawn flexed his digits and marveled a bit at how the simplicity of that action alone made him feel so much better.

The Workers ahead and behind Pawn did not look at their hands, or even move except when they walked forwards. They were not like Pawn. They kept their gazes straight and did not talk. And they gave Pawn more room than strictly necessary.

He was the odd one out. Pawn knew that, but he tried not to take advantage of his position. When he stood in line the Worker gave him the same amount of brown-grey paste as the other Workers. Perhaps if he'd asked for more, he would have received it, but the calculated ration was enough to sustain him throughout the day. Besides, no one would ever *ask* for more of the Worker's food than normal.

Pawn stood in the food consumption area and slowly ingested the muck he had been given. There were no seats for the Antinium to eat at; they simply collected their rations on earthenware bowls and ate as efficiently as possible before depositing the bowls to be used again by more Workers filing into the room.

Workers and Soldiers ate separately. This wasn't because one group ate better quality food than the other—they all ate the same highly-caloric mush, but Soldiers just ate three times as much as Workers, and thus used different containers, necessitating a separate room to feed in. Pawn stared at the brown clump of mushed up...something...as he put it between his mandibles and chewed. The food went down easily, but the taste—

He had grown used to it. Even so, it was never what one would call easy. The Workers ate the food quickly, showing no signs of disgust, even though Pawn knew they had to be tasting exactly what he did. If they had gag reflexes—or an alternative food source, it might have been a different matter.

But food was food, and there were no alternatives. Except at Erin's inn. Pawn could remember having delicious meals there, and he had to force

himself to eat the rest of the mush. He *crunched* down on something on his last bite. Something hadn't been fully processed? He swallowed it anyways. It was a nice interlude from the rest of the mush. Perhaps it had been a bone fragment.

Then, as soon as they had finished eating, the Workers moved as one out of the large cavern used for food preparation and into the tunnels to begin their daily duties. Pawn followed them, not pausing to duck even though the ceiling of the tunnel was barely a foot over his head.

That was another feature of the Antinium Hive in Liscor. While some of the cavernous rooms were indeed quite large, designed to hold large numbers of the Antinium, many parts of the Hive had been optimized for space. Thus, the tunnels used solely by Workers were barely large enough to accommodate them. They had only a foot of height as they marched through the cramped corridors built to accommodate exactly two Workers at a time. And such was the flow of Workers going to their daily duties—

Well, any creature with a hint of claustrophobia would have suffered greatly. Pawn didn't mind; it was what he was used to. He walked with hundreds of other Workers as they walked through the tunnels and around each other in a perfect, synchronized flow of traffic that never halted or wasted time. Hundreds of Workers moved in every direction, going aboveground to work for the city, or below to dig or shore up collapsed tunnel walls, fulfill other tasks around the Hive, and so on.

This was only one of the shifts of Workers that worked throughout the day. Pawn was one of the Workers who slept from just before midnight to around dawn, so he considered himself close to a 'normal' sleeping habit. But there were other Workers who would sleep in the middle of the day. It didn't matter; all time was the same in the Hive.

Pawn walked down the narrow Worker corridors until he came to a main intersection in the Hive. Here, traffic diverged and more bodies entered the ceaseless cascade of motion. Larger Soldiers marched in huge columns down the massive highway of bodies, going to reinforce weak spots in the Hive, to eat, or just to rest until they were called on again. Here the Workers joined other flows, moving deeper into the Hive, or up above.

Pawn walked forwards, following the Worker ahead of him until he came to the split in the traffic. There he paused, uncertain. The Worker behind him paused, and so did the Worker behind him, and behind him and so on. In an instant, thousands of bodies stopped for one crucial second

until the Worker behind Pawn awkwardly walked around him. The Worker behind him followed the motion and so did the Worker behind him and behind him...

Instantly, the flow of traffic resumed. Unlike traffic in Erin's world, the Workers did not hesitate. They moved in perfect synchronization, so that after the initial pause, traffic flow resumed without any pileups as it were. Even so, the incident had cost all the Workers following Pawn a precious second of inactivity. Pawn knew he should feel guilty, but he didn't.

He stared at the bodies walking around him. Here were Workers, going to their duties. Across from him, another stream of Soldiers was rapidly advancing down the hallway, nearly running. They might be off to fight monsters.

Part of Pawn wondered what would happen if he walked in front of them. Would the Soldiers just trample him? They did that to other Workers who accidentally got in their way. But would his status as an Individual mean they'd avoid him?

He decided not to test this theory. Instead, Pawn resumed walking, resulting in a micro-second of delay as he rejoined the flow of Workers. He walked upwards, up towards a special room built near the surface of the Hive.

A large room had been sectioned off and given a new purpose. Instead of acting as another feeding room, the low-ceilinged area had been filled with cushions, small rectangular wooden boards filled with pieces, and even the odd chair. Antinium, all Workers, sat around these boards, playing chess.

They all paused when Pawn entered the room. The Workers looked up at Pawn, and then resumed playing. He stared around the room, looking at all the seated Antinium playing chess.

In truth, the dirt ceiling was too low to really allow any Workers to sit on the chairs. They sat around the chess boards on the dirt instead, completely ignoring the cushions that had been piled neatly in one corner of the room and never been used.

There were around sixty Workers in the room at the moment, all engaged in a board game. None of them looked up from their games, and they moved at very regular intervals. The rhythmic *click* of wooden pieces gently tapping on the board soothed Pawn. But he did not sit down at an

empty board as he usually did. If he had, he would have had an opponent in seconds. But Pawn didn't want that today.

Instead, he sat with his back to one of the dirt walls. Pawn stared ahead, not really at the chess players. They were all new Individuals, the few that had survived and not become Aberrations like the rest. They had chosen names, and they were all learning to play chess, as per the recommendations Pawn had made to Klbkch.

But they were not...like him. Pawn knew that. These new Individuals were not like he was. Nor were they like the original Individuals, the original Workers that had chosen names.

"Hah."

Pawn chuckled out loud at the ridiculousness of *that* thought. Instantly, every Worker in the room paused in their chess playing and looked up at him as one. He froze in place, unsure of what to do. After a second the Workers returned to playing as if nothing had happened.

That was it. Pawn closed his mandibles and made sure not to make another sound as the sounds of chess resumed. These new Individuals had names, but they didn't have what he and the others had. They still obeyed orders like any other Worker, and they didn't express their opinions. They hadn't developed personality like he, Bird, Belgrade, Anand, and Garry, the only surviving original Individuals had. It wasn't these new Individuals' fault, of course. They had been forced into the choice, they hadn't made it themselves. They didn't have...Erin.

Things had been simpler a few months ago. Back then, the Hive had made sense to Pawn. There were Workers and Soldiers, the Prognugator, and the Queen. That was how it had been. But now there were Workers and Soldiers yes, and the Queen, but they had a Revalantor who also acted as a Prognugator in the form of Klbkch. He had kicked the former Prognugator who was also the new Prognugator, Ksmvr, *out of* the Hive. And there was a new group of Antinium.

The Individuals. Over a hundred Workers who had chosen names and been tested for individuality without becoming Aberration. But in that group of Individuals, there were five...leaders.

No, not leaders. Five exceptions. Five of the *original* Individuals who had become so of their own volition, to save a Human named Erin Solstice. They had been the chess club, her chess club, the Workers who had played

at her inn every few days. And they had given their lives, almost all of them, to protect her from the undead.

That was the real change in the Hive. Five Antinium had chosen and become Individual, taking classes and names and true personalities. They had begun to level up rapidly like any other species, and they had become...

Unique. And it had to be said, of the five, one in particular stood out. Pawn.

He was the first. Pawn knew that. He had been the first to choose a name, the first to choose. Because of that everyone treated him as if he were special. Klbkch, the Queen—they gave him no duties, no responsibilities. They just watched him to see what he would do. And Pawn had no idea what to do, so most days he just walked up to the chess room and either played games or sat like this.

He didn't do much. Pawn just sat here, day after day. Thinking, really. That was all he could do. He was no gifted warrior like Bird, and nor was he particularly interested in other classes like Garry, Belgrade and Anand. Already the other four had begun to specialize in their roles just as his Queen had hoped. Bird had begun using a bow to harvest a large number of his namesakes even in the wintery climate, and Garry had learned to fry them and make a palatable snack out of their carcasses.

Belgrade and Anand had continued to improve in their [Tactician] class. They had already fought numerous engagements against the dungeon monsters in the tunnels below. They were all becoming assets to the Hive. But Pawn was different.

All the Workers knew it. Pawn knew it. He was different. He was the Worker that Erin had first spoken to, the first Worker to choose his name. Even the other four treated him differently. Because he was first. He was special. He hadn't just chosen, he had *been chosen* by Erin.

He was unique. But Pawn had no idea what that meant.

He knew what his Queen wanted, what Klbkch wanted. They wanted him to become a useful warrior, or an asset to the Hive. They wanted him to specialize, to level up in a class and surpass normal Antinium in that way. But Pawn hadn't done that.

Yes, he had the [Tactician] class. But he wasn't that high-level in it. In fact, he'd stagnated his growth weeks ago. Pawn still loved to play chess,

and he was the best player among the Workers by far. But like Erin, he had ceased to level.

And he had no interest in using a bow like Bird. He didn't like to cook, only to eat, and he had no burning desire to do anything else in the Hive. Pawn was sure that if he walked anywhere in the Hive—save perhaps the Queen's room—he could find something to do.

There was always work to do in the Hive. Since he had been allowed aboveground, Pawn had learned something of the customs of other species. Apparently boredom was something their peoples had to fight against. It was an alien concept in the Hive.

Were you done with your assigned duties? In that case, there was always time to be spent processing the nutritional paste the Antinium ate, chewing food up and regurgitating it into a vat to be mixed up with long poles. Or you could be sent to guard against monsters attacking from the dungeon underneath Liscor, supporting the Soldiers in their tireless battle.

And if neither of those two options were viable, you could be assigned to monitor the larvae, or maybe dig. There was always time to dig. You could dig out a collapsed tunnel, dig a new tunnel, dig a deeper tunnel, widen a tunnel, dig out a room, dig into a promising mine shaft, dig out a hole for excrement...

Occasionally, the Workers would build something. That was a refreshing change of pace. They would make wooden load-bearing supports to hold up the titanic weight of the dirt overhead, or fashion crude arrows out of wood. But even that grew tiring after hours of monotonous work blended together.

It wasn't for Pawn. He knew that. He knew he wanted something different. And perhaps he had found it. Perhaps.

But he was no longer sure. The certainty, the faith that had filled him weeks ago had long since departed, and now Pawn could only rely on uncertain memory to fill the hole in his heart. Had it really happened? Was it true?

Was he really an [Acolyte]? What did it mean?

"I don't know."

Another pause, and the Workers looked up. This time Pawn stared back, just to see what would happen. They looked down as one, and he went back to thinking.

Once upon a time, an Antinium had been questioned. He had been asked who he was, and he had no answers. He had wondered why his... friends...had all died, whether it was all for nothing. And he had been given an answer. A ray of hope.

“Faith.”

So the girl had told him. She had reached down into his despair and offered him something to hold onto. She had spoken to him of something beyond his understanding. A God. And a place...a place where the dead might go to rest. A wonderful place.

“Heaven.”

Pawn sighed, and clenched his still-healing fist. He stared at it. Yes, that night he had believed. And his belief had become reality! He had gained a Skill, and a class. [Acolyte], and the Skill, [Prayer]. It had meant something to him at the time, he had been sure.

There was a God. There was something to believe in. But in the days since, Pawn’s faith had wavered. He had not leveled again, and neither had he prayed. Because...because he was afraid.

There was a God. Erin had told him that. Not just a God, though. Gods. She had talked about a God who was born and died in her world, but apparently that God wasn’t the only one. Other people believed in a God who was the same, but different, but who had never said certain things.

“Are you even there? Will you answer me? Am I worthy of asking you such things?”

No response. The Workers looked up at Pawn and down at their chessboards. He looked up at the ceiling, in the direction Erin had told him heaven probably lay. He saw only dirt.

Heaven. Faith and Gods were all confusing to Pawn, but the idea of Heaven, the idea of forgiveness and a place to be happy was what he had clung to. He had believed in that, and so been rewarded. But if he was to pray, as his Skill seemed to indicate, then to who? To Erin’s God? Only...he wasn’t her God. That’s what she had said. So then, who did he pray to?

And for what? Why? What would it do? And would anyone answer? Would anyone care, or would his words go unheard?

Pawn didn’t know. He hadn’t known for the last week, and he was no closer sitting in the corner of the chess room. Part of him didn’t want to know. Another part told him to talk to Klbkch and his Queen, tell them of his new class. But the last part wanted to believe. It wanted to know of this

God, and to put his self into believing in that God. To reach that place called 'Heaven'.

But he was afraid. Afraid of knowing the truth. So Pawn sat in the chess room instead, wondering what would happen if he prayed. Would nothing happen? Or would something, someone answer? Which would be worse?

Pawn didn't want to know. But he wanted to, desperately. He was afraid that if he went back to Erin, she would tell him he was wrong. That his class was a mistake. That God only existed in her world. Or—

Or that there was a God, but not one for him.

That was his greatest fear. There was a God. Probably. The class he'd received seemed to indicate that. And Pawn wanted to believe in a God. But what if God didn't want him? Pawn was too afraid to ask.

So as the day passed, he sat quietly in the chess room, thinking. His mind spun in the same circles, over and over again. Workers walked into the room, played chess, walked out. They had their duties. But Pawn had nothing. Not a thing. He only had a question, and an answer he was too afraid to face.

And then, just as soon as he'd woken up, it was nightfall. Pawn knew this because of the clock in his head and the Workers on duty, not from any change in the ambient light. He stood up, stretched; the other Workers waited for him to do or say something. But Pawn just walked out of the room.

This time he went up. Up, to the city above. It wasn't his choice; Pawn just felt his feet carrying him that direction. He went up, out of the tunnel that was one of the entrances to his Hive. He walked out into the streets of Liscor, around Drakes and Gnolls and Humans who gave him a wide berth in any case. He walked out of the gates of Liscor, and through the snow, up towards the small inn whose windows shone with inviting warm light.

He had to know. He had to ask, at least. Pawn had felt the certainty in his body. He had gained a class and Skill and that meant something. There was a God. But would God accept Pawn? He had to know, and so he had to ask Erin. She would know what to do. She always did.

But Erin wasn't there. Pawn knocked at the door and then opened it, and saw the girl lying on the ground. She looked up at him, and she was not Erin.

"Excuse me? Is Erin Solstice here?"

"Erin?"

The girl had been curled up into a ball. Now she sprang to her feet and wiped at her face. Her cheeks were wet, and her eyes were red.

“What are you—you’re that Antinium, aren’t you? Pawn?”

“That is so. Is Erin here? I would like to speak with her.”

“Erin? You haven’t heard?”

The girl laughed almost hysterically. Pawn would have frowned if he were able.

“Heard what? Has something happened to Erin Solstice?”

“She’s—gone.”

“Gone?”

Pawn listened incredulously as the young woman explained what had happened. Erin had vanished? How could this have happened? How could anyone have *allowed* this?

Part of him longed to run out the door, to gather Bird and Garry and the others and immediately search for Erin. But she was safe? In another city?

“She’s safe. But she’s not coming back yet. I don’t think she can with all the Goblins around.”

The Antinium’s mind raced as he considered the implications. Goblin armies. Of course Erin’s safety came first, but if she couldn’t come back—should someone send an escort? Did Klbkch know? He must, but would he send the Soldiers out to guard her? What if—

“So...are you here for something?”

Pawn looked back at the young woman in surprise. Yes, she had stayed here, hadn’t she? Who was she? Someone new?

Lyonette. That was her name. He vaguely remembered Erin hiring her, but hadn’t she been a bad employee? Now the young woman was alone. She wiped at her nose as she pointed at the kitchen.

“Do you want...something to eat?”

Pawn’s first instinct was to refuse, but that would have meant he had to leave the inn. And he wasn’t ready to go back down into the Hive. Not yet. So he nodded, and told Lyonette he could not digest gluten. That threw her for a loop, but she eventually offered him eggs and bacon.

Pawn was under the impression such food was reserved for breakfasts, at least according to Erin, but he accepted. He still had the coins Klbkch had given him to spend. Enough for many meals.

The Worker sat at an empty table as Lyonette rushed into the kitchen and began to bang things about. He stared at the wooden grain, trying to

think. Everything was chaos in his mind now.

“Erin is gone.”

There was no one to answer his question. Pawn felt immediately relieved, and then horrible at once. He was no closer to his answer, and the question was tearing him apart. If Erin could not answer him, then—

“Here’s your food!”

A plate was shoved in front of Pawn’s face. He stared at it, and the hand holding it. Lyonette looked anxiously at Pawn as she put it on the table in front of him.

“Sorry. It’s a bit—”

The bacon was slightly burnt. The eggs hadn’t been fully cooked and they ran a bit. Pawn poked at the food with a fork once Lyonette remembered to give him one. He cautiously took a bite of the greasy bacon and chewed.

It wasn’t like the paste the Workers ate at all. It had been so long that Pawn had nearly forgotten the taste of hot food. And *salt!* Pawn finished the plate and a second helping when Lyonette offered.

Then he sat in the inn, watching the fire fade. It was funny. He had come here searching for answers, and found none. But even without them, he had found an answer of sorts.

Erin was gone. She might be in trouble, but there was no way Pawn could help her. Not as he was. He was useless, a Worker alone. But if there was a God—

There was no Erin. So there was only one person he could ask. One person who might know what this all meant. Klbkch. He had been assigned to watch over Pawn, and it was Pawn’s duty to inform him of any new classes he obtained. He had not done so before, because he was unsure. But now? Now was the time.

He would tell Revalantor Klbkch about his class and ask him what it meant. Perhaps Klbkch would know of Gods. Pawn dug at the belt on his waist and left what he thought was close to an appropriate amount. Usually Erin told him the meal was on the house.

Slowly, Pawn walked out of the door and into the snow. He was no less lost than before, but at least there was something warm inside him. He stared up at the clouded sky. He couldn’t sense heaven up there. Nor could he tell if there was a God.

But maybe there was one. And if there was, Pawn would find him. Slowly, he began to walk through the snow, back into the city, to his Hive. Gods. Heaven. He tried to believe. This time, Pawn thought he might have succeeded.

Lyonette watched Pawn go, silent, walking into the snow as he stared upwards. The Antinium had said barely a few words to her all night. He had sat, staring at the fire. But he had also eaten two of her plates and left—

She stared down at the pile of coins on the table. Silver and bronze coins glinted in the moonlight. Trembling, Lyonette scooped up the pile of coins. She counted them. Once, twice, again.

It was enough. More than enough. With this, she could feed herself for several more days. And if he came back—

Lyonette's heart skipped. Part of her wanted to shout in revulsion at even touching something the Antinium had touched. She still remembered stories about what they had done, what horrible atrocities they had committed. But this one—Pawn—he had paid her.

Maybe it was just one time. But Lyon remembered the Antinium coming into Erin's inn like clockwork. And they weren't picky; they'd even loved the bees, disgusting as they'd been. They were a stable, profitable source of income. If she could stomach serving them, maybe, just maybe, she'd survive.

The [Princess] stared out the window at the Antinium's lonely form as he walked back to the city. She could do it. She could live until Erin got back. She *would* do it, and she would show Erin she was capable. She would run this inn, and it would be her castle, her sanctuary until Erin came back.

All would be well. Lyonette had to believe in that.

1.00 D

She owned a hamster, once. That was the reason she'd wanted to be a doctor. She found other reasons later, but the day she decided to learn to heal people was when she sat in the garden outside her house and tried to hold her dying friend together.

Normally, she would want to be a vet, but her parents had talked her out of that. And her aunt had died when she was twelve. She'd stared down at the closed casket and dreamed of being able to save even people who had to be buried in pieces.

And in her last years of high school she'd had the right grades. And she liked biology, she didn't throw up into her frog like the boy next to her in class, and she didn't have anything else she wanted to do.

So she'd taken pre-med classes when she wasn't partying with friends and learning how to live alone. And she'd graduated on time and gone into Medical School, and found that it was hard to manage rent and a part-time job, but not too hard to learn. And then, one day, she'd had to go to the bathroom during a lecture and she'd never come back.

Geneva Scala had found herself in another world. And there she'd learned one thing: she didn't want to be a doctor. Not anymore. She was a [Doctor] now, but all she did was watch people die.

The person lying on the crude operating table Geneva had set up was screaming in agony. The blade had cut deep into his side, and he was bleeding to death before her eyes. If she didn't close up his injuries soon, he would be dead.

With one hand, Geneva held a crude wooden device that looked like pliers. She used that to close the artery she'd found and prayed that she could move fast enough.

"Suture!"

She screamed it at the soldier watching with wide eyes. He stared at her. She pointed to the needle and thread.

“I need to close the wound!”

She let another man take over applying pressure on the artery as she held out her hand for the needle. The soldier fumbled with the needle and nearly dropped it onto the dirt floor. Geneva snatched it out of his hands and looked at the thread.

It was just cotton; not even good quality. She'd boiled it, but now she wondered if it would even hold under the pressures she was about subject it to. But then the man screamed and she was out of time.

“Hold him still.”

The two other men did as she ordered, holding the screaming man down as Geneva desperately started to stitch. It was horrific; the needle she'd bought wasn't sharp enough and she had to poke massive holes in his flesh to try and close the gaping wound in his side. And the blood—

“Keep that artery closed!”

She snapped that at one her assistants. He tried to do as she instructed, but the forceps he was using were made of wood, and they were crude; carved in a single day, more like chopsticks than a true clamp. They slipped, and blood squirted into the man's stomach.

“Reapply pressure!”

Geneva had to shout it over the man's screams. He was gagging with pain, still half-awake. But she had no anesthetics, nothing to give him. And now the other man was trying to grasp the artery and failing to find it in the heaving wound. Geneva reached for the forceps and hesitated. The man had gone still.

Slowly, she stared at the flow of blood. It had slowed. She looked at the soldier's wide, open eyes, and then around the tent at her assistants. They stared at her. Geneva took a breath, and then spoke.

“He's dead.”

Part of her wanted to add the time of death, but that was pointless. There was no one to record it, and besides, there was no point. Even as she dropped the forceps and needle into the bowl of boiled water and watched the liquid turn red, she knew she had no time to even mourn.

“Take him outside. Bury him. I'll be out in a second.”

The soldiers haltingly moved to obey her orders. Geneva stared at her hands. They were so red. She had no surgical gloves on, and she'd cut herself earlier that morning. She was not sterile.

Slowly, the young woman glanced around. She was standing in a tent; not an airtight one, just canvas walls and a dirt floor. Her 'operating table' was a piece of hardwood. Her surgical tools were a sharpened dagger, a curved sewing needle and inferior thread, and some wooden instruments that were already covered in blood. The men and one woman who assisted her weren't trained; they weren't even clean. They were covered in blood and grime.

And she had let another man die in front of her. Geneva still heard his screams. She'd already forgotten his face, but she remembered him begging her as they'd carried him in. He'd asked her to save his life.

And she had failed.

He was the fifth person she'd seen die in front of her eyes. But she could hear shouting, and in the distance, screams. She knew that she would see more corpses before the end of the day. Geneva prayed they wouldn't be because of her.

Nearly a week ago, Geneva had walked into a city built onto the side of a lake. She'd stared around at the tall buildings, the interconnected bridges that ran overhead, and most especially at the walking lizard-people and the Centaurs that walked around next to Humans. But she hadn't stared too long. Instead, Geneva had walked further into the city, until she could hear people shouting and the *rat-tat-tat* of someone banging on a drum.

The enlisters for the local mercenary groups and larger companies were already hard at work despite the heat of the day. Humans wearing light leather armor stood at small booths next to Centaurs who were practically unarmored save for a padded cloth vest or two, and Dullahans, strange, humanoid creatures who wore armor over their entire bodies and raised their heads up as they shouted at potential recruits.

Fighting men and—no, warriors of every species were talking to these recruiters and debating which group to join amongst themselves. Geneva stared at a Minotaur holding a huge spiked club and shuddered as she imagined what would happen if it hit her. She prayed she wasn't making a mistake. But she had no choice. Her stomach was empty, and even the smell of sweat and various body odors was making her hungry.

"You there! Join the Raverian Fighters!"

A tall man wearing plate armor called out to Geneva across the square. She walked over to him, noting how sweat stood out on his brow. He must have been cooking in the heat, but he made an impression among the more lightly-armed warriors.

“My name is Thriss. I am a [Sergeant] enlisted in the 4th Battalion of the Raverian Fighter’s Company. If you’ve got the grit to fight with me, we’ll offer you eight silver coins for each day you see combat, and one for each day you don’t. Stick with us and you’ll have a hot meal each night, trustworthy comrades at your back, and all the loot you can walk off with!”

Geneva had heard every recruiter giving the same speech, but she listened intently even so. Thriss looked her up and down as he shouted to her and the crowd in general. He had an amazingly loud voice—perhaps it was a Skill?

“We specialize in close-combat fighting, but we’ll hire anyone with a decent class.”

He eyed her skeptically.

“You don’t look like a [Warrior]. Are you a [Mage] of some kind? I’d have to ask for a list of your available spells. And we’ll provide you with armor and a weapon, unless that inhibits your spellcasting.”

She had to shake her head because the hubbub was so overwhelming. Geneva stepped forwards and shouted to Thriss as he stepped off the stool he stood on to hear her.

“I’m a Doctor! I treat the wounded! Would you hire me?”

“A [Doctor]?”

He’d spoken the words like they were special. Geneva knew he thought she had a class, although she didn’t actually have one. But he looked her up and down and shrugged.

“Anyone can pull out an arrow or pour a healing potion over a wound, but sometimes a healing potion isn’t good enough. Someone who can save a few wounded—or cut the limb off without too much blood—would be useful. If you’ve got a mark, put it on this paper.”

She was surprised. Geneva had thought she’d have to talk to countless recruiters and make her case before they hired her.

“Just like that?”

Thriss shrugged his broad shoulders at her.

“It’s an odd sort that would lie about having a [Doctor] class. We’ve got no magical items that can see your class and no one who has the [Appraise]

Skill, but you didn't claim a level. And that sort of thing gets found out right quick. If you can carry your own weight and aren't a troublemaker we'll make use of you even if you have to clean dishes most of the time. If you can't fight, well, you'll learn quick."

He eyed her intently.

"But I've heard of the [Doctor] class, even if I haven't seen one. Like a [Healer], aren't you?"

"Something like that."

Geneva lied. She'd never met a [Healer] in this world, but she hoped it was close to what she did. Thriss stared at her, and then nodded.

"If you're lying to me, we'll use you as an arrow shield. But if you're not, we'll put you to good work. Maybe you'll even earn a few levels. Speak with the Lizardfolk behind me for instructions. Welcome to the Fighters."

After that, Thriss had shown her where to sign and Geneva had been given a place to sleep in the campgrounds, a hot meal of grit-like food and boiled corn mixed with meat, and even a sword and dagger. Geneva had slept, uneasily wondering about her fate, until she'd woken in the middle of the night with a realization.

Thriss didn't want a [Doctor]. Or rather, he was taking a risk on her. But what he really wanted were bodies. The Raverian Fighters were going to battle, and aside from the money spent on feeding her and equipping her, she was just another sword to hurl against the enemy.

Her heart pounded wildly, but then Geneva had gone back to sleep. She was so tired that she only woke one time more, to slap at the mosquitos trying to feast on her. Then she'd gone to sleep. She was so tired she'd completely forgotten to ask Thriss about surgical equipment.

The next day, Geneva awoke to the sound of Thriss bellowing. It had roused her in a panic, and as she tumbled out of the rough blankets she saw soldiers all around her getting up as well.

Thriss the [Sergeant] had marched out with regular soldiers and officers and roused the hodgepodge collection of warriors he'd recruited yesterday. Geneva had stood awkwardly next to a Dullahan who held her head in her hands as they stared at Thriss. The man wasn't one for speeches. He'd

welcomed them briefly, and then told them they were going to practice fighting.

“My job is normally to whip you lot into shape before we have you fight with the rest of our forces. Trouble is, we’re already engaged to the southeast of here, so I’ve got a day to see what you’re made of before we go marching.”

So they were really mercenaries. Geneva had enlisted because she’d been desperate for food, but the reality only hit her now when Thriss told them they were heading into a battle a few days from now.

“We’re up against several groups this time. A local Centaur clan has allied with the Magehammer Company. They’ve sent two battalions and hired a few mercenary groups. We’re fighting them, supporting the Burning March Company. Don’t worry about the details; just know that we’re expecting you to fight your best. We’ll be fighting in the jungle; if any of you have terrain-based skills or knowledge of the local geography, tell me or one of the officers.”

Geneva heard a few groans, but the rest of the recruits seemed to accept this information as normal. Some of the people who’d signed up looked young—regardless of race, Geneva could recognize teenagers when she saw them. But others looked like veterans, such as the Minotaur with the spiked club who stood head and shoulders above everyone except the few Centaurs who’d enlisted.

“You lot, with me! We’re going to see what you’re made of, and if you don’t know how to fight, by the end of the day you’ll get your [Warrior] class, mark me!”

A tall Dullahan with a scar over her eye bellowed it at the recruits as she took a group of them away. Geneva hesitated. She wasn’t a soldier and she couldn’t—wouldn’t—fight. What should she do?

She found Thriss as the other officers began having the other warriors engage in practice fights. The [Sergeant] opened his mouth to bellow at her, until he remembered.

“You’re the [Doctor], aren’t you? What do you want?”

“I, um, need some supplies if I’m going to be performing surgery.”

Geneva explained her problem hesitantly. She knew how these kinds of armies worked; you received pay *after* a month or two, and it would usually be late to prevent desertions. But she needed gear.

Thriss heard her out, and she was relieved he didn't shout at her or order her to keep fighting.

"You need tools, eh? How do I know you won't run off with the money?"

"I told you, I'm a [Doctor]. I need tools to stitch flesh together, and I don't have any. Don't tell me you've never seen a doctor working?"

Geneva said the words with as much certainty as she could. Thriss shrugged.

"It's rare enough. Most folks use healing potions, but I have seen healers stitch a wound closed. Why don't you have what you need already, though?"

"I lost everything I had."

That at least, was true. She'd lost everything when she'd walked down the hallway of her school and then turned and found green foliage all around her and dirt underneath her shoes instead of sterile tiles.

Thriss eyed her skeptically.

"Hm. Prove it."

"How?"

He waved at the groups of soldiers being watched by officers.

"We always get a few injuries, even with blunt weapons. Let's see if you can help with one of their injuries."

Geneva's stomach clenched up, but she nodded. But in her mind she was desperately going over her class notes and the hands-on lessons she'd had in medical school. She hadn't graduated—she was only in her third year—! But it was too late to back out now.

Soon enough, Geneva had her chance. A young man—a redheaded teen with more confidence than actual ability—failed to raise the shield he'd been given in time. The other man fighting with him struck his shoulder and Geneva saw the young man fall to the ground and scream as his shoulder popped out of its socket.

"No one move! Back to your places!"

Thriss pushed through the circle of people and beckoned Geneva over. He stared at the writhing young man on the ground and looked at her.

"Practice blade must have broken something. Can you set the bone?"

Geneva shook her head automatically as she stared at the young man. He was trying to touch and not touch his injured arm at the same time.

“The bone isn’t broken. His shoulder is dislocated; he needs to have it set.”

Thriss’ eyes glinted and Geneva saw his lips twitch for a second. It had been a test, she was sure.

“Can you fix it?”

“I can if he doesn’t move.”

“You heard her! Hold still, lad! It’s just a dislocation; nothing to bawl about!”

Thriss slapped the young man and held him still as Geneva gingerly grabbed the arm. The young man’s skin was slippery with sweat and he was shaking, but she knew what to do. He screamed and whimpered, but Geneva had learned how to fix a dislocated shoulder. After one try she popped the arm back in place and the man stopped moaning and stared at his arm in disbelief.

“He’ll need a few weeks to recover.”

“No time for that. Here. Use this.”

Thriss pulled out a glass bottle filled with green sloshing liquid out of his belt. Geneva eyed it skeptically.

“It’s a weak potion, but it should do. Go on. Unless you’ve got a Skill or spell that will do better?”

Geneva didn’t, but she’d never seen a healing potion work before. She couldn’t let anyone know that, though, so she pulled out the cork. The smell the green liquid gave off was incredibly bad, but the young man was looking at it hopefully.

Gingerly, Geneva poured some of the green liquid on the shoulder, and watched in disbelief as the already swollen flesh receded and the man gasped in relief. The area still looked raw, though, so Geneva added a bit more of the potion until it looked completely normal.

“Good!”

Thriss accepted the two-thirds full potion from Geneva and stood up. He offered the young man a hand, and the youth took it as he stood, flexing his good arm and laughing as if nothing had happened.

“I wouldn’t waste a potion on you, but we’ve got a battle to get to, and you’re no use to us with one arm!”

Thriss’s voice echoed around the campsite and the other soldiers stopped practicing to listen.

“Mark my words, stick with us and you won’t be looking for potions when you’ve got an arrow in your stomach! We’ve got healing supplies that will take care of anything save having your head chopped off—unless you’re a Dullahan—and we’ve even got a [Doctor] in case the healing potions don’t work!”

He pointed to Geneva, and she felt eyes on her. Geneva blushed a bit, but she didn’t shy away from the attention. The rational, calm part of her was thinking, though. Thriss had had the healing potion ready, and he’d been expecting someone to get hurt. She looked at the soldier who’d been dueling the young man. He was a veteran, not a new recruit. They’d probably planned all of this out to bolster the recruit’s confidence, and testing Geneva’s involvement had only added to the charade.

Her suspicions were confirmed when Thriss took her back to his tent and he put the healing potion in a chest which he locked with a key. He looked at her as he fished around in the supplies and came up with a bag which he added some coins to.

“That was quick. I’ve seen men tear flesh trying to get the bone into place, but you did that in seconds.”

He thrust the bag at her and Geneva looked inside. A handful of silver pieces glittered at her.

“Take it and buy what you need. I’ll have one of the local boys show you around.”

So she wouldn’t run off with the money. Geneva accepted the small bag gratefully. Then she had to wait for Thriss to find a young Lizardboy to guide her. All the while she was still struggling with the unreality of it all.

Magical potions that could do several weeks’ worth of healing in a few seconds? Soldiers fighting with swords? Lizard people, Centaurs, and a race of people who could take their heads off like hats?

Just what had she gotten herself into?

It took Geneva most of the day to gather what she needed, which was to say, a needle fit for doing any kind of surgery. In truth, she would have liked some antibiotics, general and local anesthetics, a supply of needles, disinfectant—

But she knew she was going to get none of that here. So Geneva got what she knew she could get, which was a needle, a curved one, the kind that she could use to sew flesh. Regular, straight needles just wouldn't do.

Still, even finding that one instrument in the city was a challenge. It wasn't as if this world—some kind of medieval world filled with magic—had anything like modern equipment. Geneva had to talk to three [Seamstresses] until one old lizard woman had what she was looking for.

"This is a needle I use to sew carpets, not flesh, Human."

The old Lizardwoman with discolored scales eyed Geneva suspiciously, but sold her three curved needles in the end, along with the thread to match. It was dearly expensive, but Geneva still had enough left for some cloth and scissors. She needed bandages, and scissors were essential.

Thriss had eyed Geneva's purchases and snorted when she returned. He'd taken the few coppers she had left.

"Bandages? Good if you've not a healing potion on hand, I suppose. But if you need cloth, we've got enough rags. Ask the quartermaster for the rest of what you need and get ready to march tomorrow. We'll need to cover at least fifteen miles and you'll have your own pack to carry."

After that, Geneva sat with laughing males and females of various races as they ate before they slept. The air was hot and humid, as it had been every day Geneva had been here, and bugs tried to bite or drink from her. But the food on her plate was filling, and she could even smile and accept thanks from the young man whose arm she'd set.

And as the second night had come and the weary new recruits were bedding down, Geneva had curled up into her blankets and covered her head so no one could see her. That was the moment when she allowed herself to shake and choke on her fears.

What was she doing? She didn't have any real equipment. She needed proper surgical gear, not sewing needles and bits of cloth. She needed forceps, a sterilized operating room, disinfectant, antibiotics, anesthetics—

"But I have no choice."

Geneva whispered that to herself until the person sleeping next to her grunted in irritation. She shut up. She had no choice. She had to survive.

This was Baleros, and the jungles were filled with monsters and the species were constantly fighting one another. If she didn't have work, she would starve or be killed. And there wasn't much use for a [Doctor], not in a land filled with magic healing potions.

Geneva Scala stared at the needle and thread in her pack and the bandages, water bottle, and pot she'd asked the quartermaster for. Her hands trembled as she imagined trying to save anyone's life with such limited supplies. She stared at the sword and remembered her Hippocratic Oath.

Not the ancient Grecian oath that forbade the use of a knife in medicine, but the one she'd sworn to herself. She'd adopted her namesake, the Declaration of Geneva, and made her own oath.

She murmured it now, half in her mind, half out loud.

"I solemnly pledge to consecrate my life to the service of humanity. I will practice my profession with conscience and dignity; the health of my patient will be my first consideration; I will respect the secrets that are confided in me. I will not use my medical knowledge to violate human rights and civil liberties, even under threat..."

She fell asleep before she could finish the rest. But the words echoed in her dreams. Only, now the word humanity was wrong. She had to protect people. But she was a soldier, too. She might have to fight.

She couldn't do that. She had sworn a higher oath. Even if she was in another world, another place where magic existed and people leveled up like a video game, she had her oath.

It was the only thing she had left.

[Doctor Class Obtained!]

[Doctor Level 1!]

[Skill – Lesser Resistance: Disease obtained!]

"So you're a [Doctor]?"

That was the question Geneva received at least ten times the next day, as she found herself marching across a dirt road and into increasingly thick underbrush. The 4th Battalion of Raverian Fighters set out to join the fighting.

In truth, Geneva had no idea where they were on this continent, or where they were going. She wasn't even sure what they were fighting *for*, which amazed the soldiers who decided to speak with her on the march.

She was in 6th Squad, under Thriss himself. Their group—and indeed, most of the battalion—was Human. Oh, a few Centaurs, Dullahan, Lizardfolk, and even the Minotaur marched with them, but Geneva understood that species generally stuck together, even in mercenary groups.

“It’s easiest to coordinate attacks if everyone’s the same species for the most part. ‘Sides, we Humans have to stick together, right?’”

So proclaimed the red-haired young man who’d been the first to join Geneva on the march. He shouldered the pack he’d been given with only a little difficulty and kept stroking the hilt of his sword with clear excitement. Geneva heard a snort and saw the three men and two women walking with them laughing at him.

“Ignore Lim. He don’t know what he’s talking about. We’d be far better if we had a few more Dullahan in our company. They’ve got armor for skin; all Lim’s got is a big mouth and a bad shoulder.”

“Hey!”

Lim looked hurt as Geneva laughed. The woman who’d spoken—Clara—had dark skin, reminiscent of a Native American’s, which made Geneva more and more convinced that she was in some twisted version of the Americas. Somewhere around Brazil or maybe the Amazons—the plant life and constant, intrusive humidity and heat seemed to suggest it.

“I’m surprised you wanted to join up with the Fighters, though, Geneva. Don’t [Healers] generally stay away from the fighting?”

“I guess. But I don’t have any money, and this was my only option.”

Clara nodded sympathetically.

“Still, if you won’t be fighting you’ve got a better chance than Lim. What’s a [Doctor] do, anyways? Don’t healing potions make your class obsolete?”

“Maybe.”

That’s what Geneva had been worrying about. She shook her head.

“Healing potions don’t work on everything, though, right?”

“True.”

A man with a thick beard and bald head nodded sagely. He had several scars that made Geneva wonder whether they’d been healed naturally or whether the healing potion hadn’t quite worked.

“A good healing potion’ll put together some broken bones and mend skin and even your guts, but a bad one only does a bit of healing. ‘Sides, do you think we’ve got enough potions to fix everyone up? Thriss made a big

show earlier, but if you're counting on being healed up every time you take a hit, you'd best run away now. Only way to stay healthy is not get hit."

The other soldiers nodded and Lim looked worried for a second.

"But we won't be in that much danger, right?"

"Hah! Against Centaurs? They might have trouble in the jungle, but get them on a flat plain and they'll pepper you full of arrows so fast that you won't even have time to reach for your shield."

"Centaurs ain't the problem here. I'm more worried about the Magehammer Company. They've got some nasty mages."

"They're not *all* going to be mages, are they?"

Again, everyone laughed at Lim. He flushed and turned red, but eyed Geneva sideways. She pretended not to notice—he couldn't have been more than sixteen, and she was twenty four, going on twenty five.

"They've probably got mostly warriors and only a few mages in each squad, if that. And we've got our own mages so we needn't worry about being completely alone. But mark me, there are going to be some nasty spells out there."

"We're not going to be fighting them the entire time, though, right?"

"Of course not! Do you think we're going to kill them down to the last man? No, we're trying to push back their company. If we kill enough of them—or take enough land, their Commander will probably sign a peace treaty. Then we all get paid and we can get drunk for a week or two."

Clara lectured Lim as Geneva listened with rapt attention. She'd been in this world, in Baleros, for a week, and she'd survived mainly by pretending she knew the basics of this world. But she was still woefully undereducated, and the people marching with her were the first people she could candidly ask questions of.

"The Magehammer Company is trying to protect a goldmine that Centaur tribe found. That's what I heard. They're going to split the profits, but surprise, the Burning March Company claims that's their mine because they've got the contract on this area."

Several other people nodded sagely. Lim looked confused.

"But who's right?"

"Who cares? We get paid to fight, not take sides. Don't go making an enemy of a Company, boy."

The bald soldier cuffed Lim. From what Geneva understood, Baleros was a continent unique in that despite there being nations and countries and

kingdoms and so on, much of the fighting was done by mercenary groups, ranging from smaller troops like the Raverian Fighters to huge Companies comprised of multiple regiments of soldiers who were almost constantly embroiled in conflict.

“Of course, the Companies are like nations themselves.”

Clara looked surprised when Geneva asked her about it.

“New to Baleros, are you? Well, there are countless companies who have their own cities and towns where they base themselves. They have contracts and earn income from protecting places, and they send out their own armies to fight. The big ones have influence, representatives in other nations, even entire merchant organizations that cater only to them!”

Geneva nodded.

“I’ve heard the Four Companies of Baleros are the biggest. But I don’t know anything about them...why doesn’t everyone join up with them?”

“The Four Companies? Well, sure, if you’re an officer or a veteran they treat you well. But you can get better pay and opportunities to loot and level up in a mercenary group. Besides, when they go to war, people die by the tens of thousands.”

The bald man shook his head and spat. He was called ‘Old Man’ by a lot of the soldiers, but his actual name was Fortum. He used the spear in his hands like a walking stick as he talked, his mouth a mix of yellow teeth and conspicuous gaps.

“They’re all somewhat equal—well, it’s not as if they fight against each other most of the time. That would upset the balance, and if two of the Great Companies fought, the other two would attack the winner, if there even was one. But now that we’re mentioning it...Lim, you know the Four Great Companies, right? Tell the young lady about them?”

“Me?”

Lim jumped and blushed. He cleared his throat nervously.

“Well, there’s the Armored Legion—the Dullahans—”

“Dullahans and a lot of bastards in armor. They base themselves in the north, mainly. They’ve got at least eighteen cities under their protection.”

Fortum interrupted Lim.

“Well yeah, but their leader’s a Dullahan, right?”

“As if that made a difference! They’ll take anyone with good armor. I doubt you’d get much work with them, Geneva. All their troops are tough as nails and their Dullahans have metal armor.”

The Old Man nodded to some of the Dullahans marching in a squad ahead of them. Geneva looked, and saw those Dullahans had ‘skin’ made of wood, not metal. She’d been surprised when she saw that, but apparently while Dullahans were all covered in armor save for their head, the quality of that armor varied.

“Not a lot of treatment needed for people wearing armor, right?”

“Maybe.”

Geneva could just imagine the injuries that might occur. Crushed bones, pierced armor—she shuddered as she imagined trying to restore a smashed hand without equipment. She wasn’t even sure she could help someone who got cut by a sword here.

“Anyways, they’re always at odds with the Flowing Wind Company. Mainly Centaurs, but they have a lot of mounted soldiers as well. They specialize in fast strikes—one second you think you’re safe and the next their armies will come riding down on you during the night. Not so great in jungles and higher up, though.”

Baleros wasn’t all deep forest and jungles. It had wide open plains and wonderfully scenic landscapes—or so Geneva had been told. If it was anything like America, she expected the northern part of the continent would be far colder.

She’d been born in Wisconsin, and although she was Italian by heritage and had often visited her homeland—this humidity was killing her. She would give anything for a bit of snow. Apparently it was *winter*, but for some reason it was delayed. She’d heard Winter Sprites mentioned in this context, but Geneva still had no idea what that meant.

“The Armored Legion and Flowing Wind companies are specialized, but the other two are more diverse. The Forgotten Wing for instance—”

“That’s the army with the Fraerling who leads them, isn’t it?”

“The Titan himself. Yeah, they rose into prominence two decades back. Crushed countless other companies, and their second-in-command is the Titan, the greatest [Strategist] in the world.”

Fortum nodded, and Geneva wondered what a Fraerling was. The Old Man cleared his throat.

“Mind you, their Commander is just as terrifying. The Titan leads their armies while the Three-Color Stalker takes down enemy officers. They haven’t as many long-term contracts, but they’re a rising force, and they’ve been fighting with the Iron Legion. Now, the last company—”

“Ambush! Centaurs in the trees!”

Someone screamed the words from up ahead. Geneva looked up, and then, suddenly, there were arrows.

Geneva stared at shadows as they burst from the trees. She felt something blur past her face, and then someone tackled her from the side. Lim’s terrified face hovered above her as Geneva hit the ground and all the air rushed out of her lungs.

Stunned, she saw a Centaur covered in warpaint and nothing else leap over her. He had a bow in his hands and he nocked it and fired three times. Three soldiers around him fell, crying out, and then he was running into the trees.

He had raven hair, and tanned skin. And he had a bracelet which shone with magical light. The Centaur’s galloping footsteps faded, and only then did Geneva sit up.

The first thing she heard were screams, and confused shouting.

“Attack, attack!”

“Go after them!”

“No, hold position! Get some potions out here!”

“They’re all dead!”

“Where are the archers!?”

“Potions! I need—!”

And then, a voice from next to her.

“Clara!”

Lim stared at one of the fallen soldiers. Geneva looked over and saw Clara was weakly grasping at a shaft buried in her collarbone. It felt as though the ground had dropped underneath Geneva.

Arrow wound. A deep shot. Probably hit bone; not bad blood loss yet, but Clara’s eyes were wide and she was gasping. First stage of hypovolemic shock?

Lim staggered over to the female soldier. He choked as he stared at the shaft in her body and reached for it.

Geneva was still in shock, but her training and instincts took over.

“Don’t touch her!”

She snapped at Lim as he reached for the arrow. Geneva looked around. Fortum was watching out for the archers, but other soldiers were already charging into the forest.

“Fortum! Help me lie her down.”

He hesitated, but then abandoned his spear and helped Lim lie Clara down. She was gasping and her face was white as Geneva studied the arrow.

Geneva had gone through a surgical rotation in medical school, but while her lessons had included information about how to fix up people with bullet wounds and knife wounds, no one had even thought to include a seminar about arrows. But the basic principle Geneva understood. She could either leave the arrow in and let it fester, or get it out.

The only problem was in *how* to get it out. Geneva had nothing like a scalpel and she was well aware of the dangers of infection. The arrow tip might be poisoned for all she knew. She had to get it out, but if Clara died then what was the point? Moreover—she'd have to cut down to the arrowhead itself to extract it.

She had butterflies in her stomach, but Geneva's mind was cold. You had to be cold to work as a surgeon. And quick, too. There was no room for hesitation in the emergency room or the battlefield.

"I need a knife, and hot water. And a healing potion."

She could bypass the injury she was about to inflict on Clara by using a potion. But there was still the issue of infection—did a healing potion erase bacteria or was that still an issue?

"Sergeant Thriss!"

Lim shouted desperately, and then the big man was running to them, a healing potion in his hands. He looked down at Clara, and then at Geneva.

"Can you save her?"

"I can."

Geneva said it instantly. Even without a healing potion, the wound wasn't that bad. And with it, she could take the arrowhead out. The only issue was whether the trauma of the surgery would be too much for Clara.

When she asked about the issue of infection, Thriss shook his head.

"The better type of healing potion gets rid of poison and all kinds of nasty problems, but we've only got cheap stuff."

"Fine. Then I need a fire *now*."

"[Mage]! I need a mage over here!"

Thriss *roared* and a man in robes ran over. He blinked when Geneva demanded a fire, but he immediately boiled the pot of water just by putting a glowing hand on the metal. Geneva dunked the knife Fortum handed her in the water and tried to breathe slowly.

She only had a knife. She needed—she needed clamps, forceps, retractors—she needed a damn *scalpel*. This dagger had all the precision of a baseball bat. And she needed something to dig around in the injury with.

“I need a spoon. Or—a metal knife. Something small I can work with.”

Lim went running, and Geneva knelt by Clara. The woman was trying to sit up, but Geneva held her down.

“Clara? It’s going to be okay. Alright? But I need to get that arrow out of you, so it’s going to hurt.”

“You can help me?”

Clara smiled at Geneva, but there was worry in her eyes. Geneva nodded and tried to smile. Clara should be under anesthesia, but she was bleeding and *there was no time*.

“Here!”

Lim came back with the things Geneva had requested. She dunked them in the boiling water and took a breath. Thriss was watching her, and Fortum was staring with concern at the arrow.

“The healing potion’ll close the wound, but the shaft has to come out. It has to be cut.”

She nodded at the older man.

“Hold her down. Clara? I need you to hold still, alright?”

Clara clenched her teeth.

“Okay.”

Lim’s face went pale as Geneva drew the dagger out of the boiling water. She barely felt the scalding heat; her entire concentration was on Clara’s bleeding wound. Go in fast; avoid major arteries and veins. Dig the arrowhead out and make sure it hadn’t fragmented, then use the healing potion. Time was her only enemy. And pain.

“I’m going to start.”

So saying, Geneva slowly began to cut into Clara’s shoulder, next to the shaft. The woman *inhaled*, and Geneva paused as she saw the blood.

But she’d done this before. She’d cut open people and cadavers. But never—

Never when they were alive.

It was so hard. But she had to do it. People thought doctors swore the Hippocratic Oath when they learned to practice medicine. There was that famous line, ‘Do no harm’. *Primum non nocere*.

Bullshit. Doctors had to cause harm. It was the only way to do surgery. The only way to save lives.

So Geneva began to cut. She sawed flesh apart and Clara screamed. Fortum and another man held her down as the woman herself tried not to move, and Geneva cut fast and deep.

“Oh dead gods. Lords and ladies. *Nonononono—*”

Lim was right in Geneva’s ear, reacting viscerally to the surgery. He backed away, hands over his mouth, and then Geneva heard retching and splattering. He’d vomited! Of all the—

“*Goddamnit! Get him out of here!*”

Geneva shouted and Thriss pulled Lim away. The vomit stank in the hot air and Geneva was worried it would attract bugs. But she didn’t hurry her movements; she was working as fast as she could and didn’t dare rush for fear of causing more damage.

Cut down. Through tissue. She didn’t have time to remove the blood, even if she could. No sponges. Clara was screaming, but there! There was the arrowhead.

It was deep. And now Geneva could see it was touching bone. But she’d opened a path so she gently tried to remove the arrowhead by pulling the shaft out.

She *had* to get the arrowhead out. It was a sharp object, unlike a bullet or something the tissue could heal around. Even a healing potion would probably only form an abscess around the arrowhead until Geneva could get it out. It was better to slice up Clara’s flesh to retrieve it rather than leave it in.

If it was lodged in the bone, she’d have to pull it out with her crude forceps. Geneva prayed as she gently twisted and pulled the shaft out. Clara was moaning, deep and agonized. But Geneva’s attention was all on the shaft. She could feel the arrowhead moving, coming up and then—

The bloody head of the arrow came up, crimson with Clara’s blood. Geneva stared at it grimly and cast it aside.

“Good!”

Thriss exclaimed and uncorked the potion as soon as he saw the arrowhead. But Geneva stopped him and shook her head.

“I need to disinfect the wound first. Reboil that water.”

It was a popular myth that alcohol would disinfect wounds. While that was true, it would also inflame the injury. Alcohol was good for sterilizing

equipment; but in this case the hot water Geneva used to wash the injury and blood was adequate.

Clara screamed into the rag Fortum had given her to bite with, but in a few seconds Geneva was pouring the healing potion over the wound. She did it slowly; Geneva the person wanted to heal the wound as fast as possible, but Geneva the surgeon wanted to observe the potion's effects. What she saw fascinated her.

The healing potion was clearly some kind of agent that accelerated the body's natural processes. It did not create new skin; rather, it made the existing tissue close up at an extremely accelerated rate. Even as Geneva watched the skin close together and the angry red color of the flesh returned to its normal state, she wondered how the potion would work on another kind of injury.

They would probably do nothing for more advanced breaks, unless the bones were set properly. Even then, they would have limits—these potions couldn't heal severed limbs, and indeed they would inhibit reattachment if used incorrectly—even if that was possible to do with just potions.

Did the potions age the skin? Would they cause cancerous growths or tumors in the long run if they continued to accelerate the reproduction of cells? What would their effect be on such an affliction?

Thoughtfully, Geneva corked the potion and handed it back to Thriss. He looked surprised, but she'd only used up half of the bottle. Despite the invasive surgery, she hadn't cut *that* deep into Clara for the arrowhead.

"Only a bit of healing potion. That's good work."

Geneva just nodded. Clara was feeling her arm and sitting up, shuddering. Tears had streaked through the blood and grime on her face, but her skin was whole and unscarred now. She hugged Fortum as the soldier gripped her shoulder.

It was hard to meet her eyes. Geneva stood up and looked at Thriss. He was looking at her too, different than before. There was a newfound respect in his eyes.

"Not many [Healers] could remove an arrowhead from a screaming person like that. I guess [Doctors] are stronger, eh?"

"Some are. But I don't have even a quarter of the equipment I need for proper surgery. If Clara wasn't the only one injured, or if the arrow had hit her in the gut—"

Thriss shook his head.

“Bad business. Those Centaur bastards are good shots. Your friend was lucky she only got struck once; I’ve seen them hit a soldier three times in as many seconds.”

He pointed at the other bodies lying on the ground. Their eyes had been closed, but Geneva could see the arrows that had struck them around the heart or in the necks and faces.

“If you can save more lives, I’ll see to getting you what you need. What things do you want? A sharp dagger, we can give you.”

“I need more than that. I need things to open skin and hold flesh. Tweezers, a digging instrument—”

Thriss’ face changed as Geneva described the tools. He shook his head.

“Talk to the [Quartermaster]. I’ll see to it you can take what’s needed.”

“I also need something to clean my tools. Not just water, although I’ll need a fire to boil water. But I need alcohol—a strong spirit.”

Disinfectants. Could she make some kind of iodine? She desperately needed an antibiotic, but what?

Thriss made a troubled face.

“We have an alcohol ration. I suppose I can have the quartermaster give you some. But if I see soldiers drinking—”

“If they’re drinking, it’s because I need them to stop screaming.”

“True enough. Well then, you do what’s needed. But it was good you were here. Damned good. I’ve seen too many friends cutting a shoulder open and rooting for the damn arrowhead, or pouring a potion on top and having the wound fester.”

He nodded to Geneva and left her. Slowly, the disturbed line of soldiers began to regroup, and in ten more minutes they were marching again. But this time they walked in silence, and Geneva stood alone. She’d washed the blood off her clothes and hands, but the other soldiers stayed away from her.

Apparently, it was one thing to kill your enemy, and another to hurt your friends, even if that was to help them. Geneva didn’t care at the moment. When they finally made camp she just fell into bed after a quick meal. She was *exhausted*.

But a voice spoke in her ears before she slept.

[Doctor Level 4!]

[Skill – Hygienic Hands obtained!]

[Skill – Lesser Resistance: Infection obtained!]

She didn't understand Skills that well. Well she did—it wasn't a hard concept to grasp. But Geneva didn't precisely understand what *her* Skills did, and that bothered her greatly.

As she woke up and felt a night's worth of bug bites start to itch, Geneva wondered what [Hygienic Hands] did. Did that mean she didn't have to wash her hands? Surely not. She had a bit of grime on them even now.

Or—was there some kind of effect on them that would nullify any bacteria on her hands? If she touched something—like feces, for example—was she cleansing the object or would it return to being filthy the moment it left her hands? Did the effect apply to the tools she used, or was it *just* her hands?

For that matter, how much resistance was 'Lesser Resistance', anyways? Was her immune system simply stronger, or would she slowly develop an immunity or would the virus or infection not affect her as badly as someone without this Skill?

She wished she had a microscope. That would answer so many questions, and besides which, this world was a veritable treasure trove of new information. Geneva would have given anything to study how the Lizardfolk and Dullahan's internal biology worked or even what effect magic had on the particles in the air when it was cast. She had so many questions.

But as she walked to breakfast where a silent Dullahan was serving bowls of soup and chunks of dry bread to the soldiers, Geneva's thoughts made way for a more pressing issue.

How would the others respond to her now that they'd seen her performing surgery? Moreover, how would Clara react?

She needn't have worried. True, Lim hesitated, but he still moved over as Geneva sat with Fortum and the other Human soldiers from this morning, and Fortum grunted at her in a friendly sounding way. The others chatted or blinked in bleary silence as was their preference, but none looked at Geneva too oddly.

Except for Lim, that was. He still looked uneasy when he met Geneva's eyes, but Clara gave her a one-armed hug the instant she saw her in the morning.

"Looks like a [Doctor]'s more use'n I thought, isn't that right? You cut that arrow out of my arm in a thrice, and it doesn't feel the slightest bit bad now!"

"I'm sorry I didn't have anything to stop the pain."

Fortum shook his head.

"You were faster than anyone I'd ever seen, girl. Don't you worry. Clara knows you had to get that arrowhead out."

"It was worth me screaming and bleeding for that."

Clara nodded seriously. She tapped her arm.

"I've heard stories of folks who used a potion without pulling the arrowhead out. They rot from the inside and die screaming. No amount of potion'll fix that."

"You were so *calm*."

Lim burst out at last. He looked at Geneva, wide-eyed.

"How did you know how to get the arrow out? Do all [Doctors] have a skill? What level do you learn to do all that?"

Geneva frowned. She hadn't learned that from her class, but the idea that someone could learn something like surgery from just leveling up a few times was...concerning. Fortum scowled and cuffed Lim lightly.

"It's rude to ask her level, boy."

Even asking about Classes was considered somewhat rude unless the information was volunteered first. It was a personal question and an important one; knowing someone's exact levels and classes meant you could tell how powerful or useful they were. Geneva only shrugged.

"I'm not a high level [Doctor], but I've been trained to do surgery and other types of medicine."

"Surgery? You mean cutting someone open like yesterday...?"

Lim looked uneasy, and another soldier smacked him on the shoulder.

"We're *eating*, boy."

Geneva nodded. She had no issues swallowing her food.

"If I have to. But I normally have a lot more tools. I was working with what I could scrounge, but next time...do you know where I can get tweezers? Even wooden ones would do."

“Someone’ll have them. But if you want some, there’s bound to be someone with a wood working Skill in this crowd.”

Fortum pointed this out, and Geneva latched on to the suggestion.

“Do you think I could pay them or get them to make me a few tools?”

Metal would be far better, but anything was better than nothing. The Old Man nodded as he chewed at his bread slowly, breaking it down with saliva and soup so his few teeth could do the rest of the job.

“I reckon they’ll do it for free, even if the sergeant don’t insist. After today, everyone’s going to want to give you as much help as they can in case they’re the ones with a hole in their gut.”

“Can you fix that, too?”

Geneva smiled wryly, but her stomach twisted.

“Let’s not find out right now, okay?”

Everyone laughed, and soon the soldiers were roused by Thriss shouting and back on the march. But the [Sergeant] found Geneva as she was walking with the others.

“A word.”

He led her away from the others, and then pressed a small key into her hands. It was made of iron and sturdy. Geneva blinked at it.

“What’s this?”

“It’s a key. To the chest of healing potions in the supply wagon.”

Thriss stared seriously at Geneva.

“You’re new, but after yesterday, me and the other officers agreed you should have it. Mark me, though. If any potions are missing or you don’t lock up, there will be hell to pay.”

She met his eyes.

“Don’t worry. I won’t steal.”

“Good! I just want you to know how important what you’ve got is. Don’t lose it, or if you do—tell me at once. We can’t lose that key.”

Geneva nodded again and Thriss clapped her on the shoulder with one hand. Geneva stared at the supply wagon as she pushed the key deep into her pockets. It *was* an important thing to be entrusted with. The potion chest was probably the most valuable thing this battalion of mercenaries was carrying.

It sat at the center of the line of troops, in a wagon that was guarded by veterans. All the precious supplies were held there, but the potions had the

double protection of the chest. Geneva could see why. Even a magical sword wasn't as valuable as the hundred plus bottles of magical liquid.

The others made no comment as she rejoined them on their march, although Fortum did eye Geneva speculatively. But none of them looked like thieves, and so Geneva found the time to talk to some other soldiers and ask about fashioning some wooden tools.

They were all friendly, even the Lizardfolk. The few Dullahans and Centaurs were somewhat aloof, but Geneva's [Doctor] status seemed to make her special.

No one seemed to really know what a [Doctor] was. Oh, they were familiar with [Healers] and regarded [Doctors] as a version of that class, but Geneva felt like she was being treated like a witchdoctor or some kind of medicine woman or midwife.

This world didn't need [Doctors]. Not like her world. That knowledge made Geneva's chest hurt and loosen at the same time. Was she useless?

No—no, Clara had still needed her help to remove the arrowhead. And things like plagues and infection might not be curable with magic alone. She had a place. And on this battlefield, at least Geneva could hand out potions.

The thought of going into battle was another worry that made Geneva's stomach twist. But again, she'd had no choice. And at least here she could learn if she could still save lives or if all her skills were obsolete.

But to Geneva's surprise, she found her expertise was needed before violence occurred again. As the soldiers had taken another break from marching and the sun was overhead, Thriss sought her out again.

"Geneva. A Dullahan wants to see you. He says it's important."

Curious, Geneva stood up and walked over to find a tall, dark-skinned man wearing armor that looked like bark was waiting for her. There was nothing visibly wrong with him, but for some reason the air smelled foul around him.

"What's wrong? Are you sick?"

"No. Hurt."

Without preamble, the Dullahan pulled off his arm. Geneva *gasped*, but Thriss didn't seem shocked.

"Never seen a Dullahan do that? It's not just heads."

The Dullahan's arm had come off smoothly, without any resistance. Geneva stared into the dark socket of his armor, but saw only purple light

and a mist coming from the hole. Did they even have organs?

The Dullahan held the arm with one hand, and pulled a panel of the armor off. Geneva found her question answered and her stomach roiled as the horrible, rotting smell intensified and she saw what was causing it.

Underneath the Dullahan's wooden armor—and now that Geneva saw what it was, she realized it was actually skin—his internal organs were clearly visible. Muscle and tendons were clearly visible; it was as if a normal Human had lost all their dermal layers but left their organs intact.

Dullahans were like *crustaceans*! They had shells – or perhaps they were more like insects, with exoskeletons they could remove. But what caught Geneva's eye and made Thriss step back in disgust was the source of the smell.

It wasn't a blood-filled injury like Clara's. No, this was an infection. Pus and yellow liquid ran from the Dullahan's arm as he held the wooden panel open, and Geneva saw the tissue and muscles around the yellow substance were raw and inflamed.

“Dead gods, that's awful.”

Thriss wiped at his mouth with the back of his hand and spat. Geneva looked at the arm. Clearly, it was a long-term infection that hadn't been treated. Her stomach tried to revolt, but Geneva held it firm. It wasn't the worst thing she'd seen. Granted, it was up there in terms of disgusting, but she was a doctor. She was already thinking of how to treat the wound without any antibiotics.

“May I?”

To her surprise, the Dullahan handed Geneva his arm. She gently held it in her hands, noting the weight—it was quite heavy. She wrinkled her nose at the injury. What she wouldn't give for gloves.

The wound was pus-filled and *stank*. Geneva stared at the Dullahan.

“Why didn't you get this treated earlier?”

He shook his head.

“No one who can help with this. Healing potions no good. No [Healer] knows how to treat Dullahans.”

“But you think I can help?”

“[Doctor] is different. May help. Must help. Arm is bad.”

It was. Geneva noted the deterioration of tissue—the area had already begun to break down. She came to a quick decision.

“I’ll need more boiled water, and clean towels. In fact, I’ll need to boil the towels in the water first.”

Thriss eyed Geneva.

“Will this take long?”

“Not too long. Less than thirty minutes if I can get what I need. But I need to clean the wound now.”

He grunted.

“Good. Do it. And do it away from camp.”

Geneva led the Dullahan to a place where the soldiers couldn’t see—or smell—his injury and got to work. He followed her quietly, and silently. He was a very still figure, and his head didn’t exhibit many facial expressions. The infected wound had to *hurt*, but he was stoic. Was that a Dullahan trait?

To begin with, Geneva tried to figure out how the infection had started. But when she asked when he’d noticed the infection, the Dullahan only shook his head. He tapped the arm plate.

“Armor broke. Bad thing got in.”

Something like a bug or dirt? No wonder Dullahans tried to upgrade their armor. It was their skin, and any holes would expose them to all kinds of dangers. Geneva did her best with the wound. She would have done anything for antibiotics, but without them—

First she boiled water and cleaned two towels as best she could. Then, she requested and received some salt. She added it to another pot of water and boiled that. When the water was no longer scalding, she used it and the towels to clean the wound.

The Dullahan sat through it all, only wincing slightly which impressed Geneva again. She was touching his internal structure however lightly, and that had to be painful. But his only motion was to shoo away the insects that were attracted to his rotting flesh.

Soon, Geneva had cleared away the injury and she could see no traces of dirt or other containments. She gave the entire area one last dose of the saline solution—knowing it was a poor substitute for a proper antiseptic—and wished one last time for antibiotics.

“Is it done?”

The Dullahan looked at Geneva as she cleaned his armor plate. There was some...fleshlike substance on the back, and she tried to be as gentle with that as possible as well. How was he able to detach it from his arm?

There was clearly still bloodflow. Was it just magic? Some kind of portal system?

She shook her head as she handed him the plate and he reattached it to his arm.

“No. Your infection is bad. Very bad. I have to clean it every few hours and let the pus drain. It will take time, you understand? But it must be cleaned, and the wound must breathe for a while.”

He nodded.

“It will heal?”

“You have a good chance.”

Geneva didn't want to lie, but neither did she want to speak her mind. She *needed* antibiotics, somehow. But this wasn't the place to find any. She hesitated. *Could* healing potions be of any help? Maybe...

“Hold on.”

When she came back with the healing potion she'd used on Clara, Geneva applied it sparingly to the Dullahan's injury. The swelling reduced, although the injury didn't look completely healed, which was something.

“I think this potion will help as well. I'll use more tomorrow and if we're lucky, your body will fight off the infection. Understand?”

He smiled at her, briefly.

“Good. Thank you.”

It was such a change to see his expressionless face move that Geneva blinked at him for a moment. But she realized he had to be terrified he'd lose his arm. She smiled back.

“It's what I do. Now, we'd better get marching.”

That was the first time someone had come to her for help. Come to that, the Dullahan was her first real patient that had consulted with her. He wasn't the last.

The Dullahan might not seem that talkative, but either he or Thriss was more chatty than Geneva thought, because word soon got out that she could do more than cut arrows out of people. Soon, Geneva had quite a number of discreet inquiries over medical issues of everything from boils and blisters to conditions like gout and even a surprising case of lacerations on a man's

groinal region. When Geneva asked where he'd gotten *that*, he just blushed and mumbled about lizardfolk.

By the end of that day, Geneva was confident enough to bring up the issue of hygiene to Thriss. He heard her out and scratched his head when she told him the soldiers needed to wash their hands regularly, not just when they were too dirty to stand.

"Soap? There is lye soap, but not nearly enough for the battalion."

"Well, you need to buy some as soon as you can. If your soldiers keep eating without washing their hands regularly, some will get sick."

Thriss made a face.

"How do you know that will help? Soldiers always get sick. It happens."

"But it will happen *less* if they do what I say and practice proper hygiene. Trust me. I'm a [Doctor]."

He hesitated, but agreed to give it some thought.

"We'll be joining up with the [Captain] and our unit's [Strategist] soon enough. You can speak with them. Tomorrow we should reach the battlefield. Your talents will be needed soon enough then, so sleep deeply."

Geneva nodded. She still had butterflies at the thought, but she was confident in her knowledge. She could help. She had to. This was what she'd been trained to do.

That night, Geneva slept on the ground, tossing and turning and thinking about antibiotics. She had to have some. Penicillin...how was that made again? Medical history hadn't been high on her list of things to memorize, and she was regretting it now. She could recite almost every human body part and countless effects of drugs, but she didn't know how to make penicillin from scratch. She needed the mold—but where would she even get it? Maybe a [Healer] would know, or some kind of class that dealt with herbs. An [Alchemist]?

Slowly, Geneva drifted off to sleep. She couldn't get it now, but as soon as she was paid and got to a large settlement of some kind she'd start searching. For now, she had to rely on the healing potions. They would make her life so much easier. If disease and infection were her only enemies, she had a chance.

The soldiers had a chance.

Geneva believed that right up until the moment she heard the screaming and galloping of hooves that broke the silence of the night.

“Attack! Get up! We’re under attack!”

Geneva heard the words as if they’d been screamed in her ear. She shot out of bed, first looking around for the danger, and then reaching for her pack. She left the sword behind as she blundered around in a panic.

People were struggling around in their bedding, shouting, adding to the confusion. Geneva nearly ran into Lim’s sword as he whirled around, looking for an enemy in the darkness.

“Geneva!”

Clara pulled Lim back and then Geneva found herself standing behind Fortum and some other soldiers from their group. They formed a circle in the darkness, watching every direction for enemies.

Someone was shouting for people to rally to him, but no one was inclined to move in the confusion. Geneva saw flashing shapes, and hoofbeats, but surprisingly, no screams. Then she heard the *crash* of wood and the sound of glass breaking and more galloping. And then...

Silence.

Slowly, order restored itself. Soldiers began to form up, and Geneva saw Thriss running through the camp, a huge mace in his hands. He ran past the group of soldiers and Geneva, and she heard a shout of rage.

“What happened?”

Lim stared at the others, wide-eyed. Geneva had a sinking feeling in her stomach. Fortum glanced around, eyeing the confusion.

“Sounds like those Centaurs hit us again. Night raid. They were in and out quick, though.”

“No one’s wounded, though.”

Clara had a deeply troubled look on her face. She looked in the direction Thriss had gone.

“What was that sound? It sounded like breaking glass.”

Geneva knew. She didn’t want to know, but there was only one conclusion that bubbled up in her brain.

“The potions.”

Lim stared at her in horror and Fortum looked grim. Soon enough they saw that Geneva was right. Thriss and another big man carried the box out

of the supply wagon and set it on the ground. Geneva saw the splintered wood and her heart stopped in her chest.

The precious chest of potions in the supply wagon had been smashed by something heavy. Inside, the fragile wrapped potions had been shattered, and the potion had leaked out of the sides. Only a few bottles held any potion at all—those Thriss and the other officers desperately tried to save, holding up the glass pieces and dripping as much potion into canteens and any containers they had on hand.

But it wasn't enough. Not nearly. Geneva saw the looks on Fortum's face and the other soldiers'. From over a hundred potions, their battalion's supply had suddenly dwindled. They had maybe less than twenty bottles' worth.

Thriss stared down at the broken chest. He stood up, and cursed, then shouted at another officer. And then his head turned. He looked at Geneva, and the look in his eyes told her that her worst fears were true. If they had no healing potions, then they only had her.

Geneva. A [Doctor]. But she had no Skills, not the ones that they needed. And she didn't have the tools. She didn't have—*anything!*

Her stomach twisted. But now Fortum was staring at her, and Clara was as well. Lim was still staring at the broken chest with horror, but all the veterans were looking at Geneva. They knew.

Slowly, every eye turned to her. Soldiers and officers alike looked at Geneva, quiet fear in their eyes.

They couldn't retreat. They were soldiers. But they feared death like all mortal beings. Without healing potions they had not a chance at all. Except if they had someone who could save them. So they put their faith in her. In Geneva, someone they barely knew, hoping because they had nothing else to cling to.

But she couldn't do it. Geneva knew that. She was unprepared. She didn't have anything she needed.

She was just twenty four years old. She was no renowned surgeon, no battlefield medic. She'd never trained. She wasn't ready!

She was a surgeon with no tools. A student who hadn't even finished her training. A practitioner without a license. A doctor alone.

But there was no one else. And she had a job to do. So Geneva stared at the box of potions and knew what was coming next. She clenched her hands so tight her knuckles cracked.

In the silence of the night, as the last drops of healing potion soaked into the jungle floor, Geneva felt death begin to walk at her side.

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“Bring in the next patient!”

Geneva snapped at the soldiers who had been assigned to her. They lurched into motion, slowly, too slowly. But they were injured as well; it was the only reason they hadn’t been sent back to the front lines. One man was limping; the other had taken a hatchet to the arm and couldn’t use it. They both should have been lying down, but she needed them.

The dead man’s gaze still haunted her vision. Geneva closed her eyes and banished the image. She sluiced more soapy water on her operating table, feeling it drain to the floor. Soapy water for disinfectant; she didn’t even have a place to drain the blood and gore. Already some bugs were buzzing around the tent. More would follow soon.

The tent flap opened. Geneva heard the woman moaning even as the soldiers carried her in on a makeshift pallet. Her arm was broken; the skin and bone deformed where something incredibly heavy had struck her.

Geneva sighed in relief. Here was someone she could fix. This woman would not die; she might not regain use of her arm, but she would not die.

She would live. And she stared at Geneva with horror in her eyes. It was probably the blood that covered her. Geneva paid no heed. Crushed bone and skin. She had no IV or drip—she had to prevent hypotension. The skin and bones—swelling. Would the arm have to be amputated?

No. No. Not yet. Check the fracture and set the bones. Geneva took a deep breath.

“This will hurt.”

She warned the female soldier and set to work. Geneva closed her ears to the screams as she worked. It was cruel. Cruel to do this. She was causing the poor woman pain, but it had to be done. There was no one else to save her, no healing potions to help her. Without Geneva hurting her, the woman would never be able to lift anything with her arm again. There were no healing potions left.

Geneva was all the battalion had.

“We will not be receiving any more healing potions in the near future.”

Thriss told Geneva that directly. The battalion had camped, and they were on the eve of their entry into the battle. Geneva stared at him as she stood in the sergeant’s marginally larger tent in their camp.

The air was hot and humid. It was dark, but a few lanterns had been set out. They were already attracting swarms of nocturnal bugs in the dense jungle.

The soldiers had camped just on the fringes of one of the dark, dense jungles that made Baleros such a nightmare to do battle in. The Centaur tribe’s goldmine was located deep within the labyrinth of trees and overgrown fauna, which meant that the attacking mercenary groups – the Burning March company hired forces like the Raverian Fighters – had to push into the jungle. It also meant close combat fighting where ambushes could happen at any moment. It would be desperate and intense, and it was made far worse because Geneva’s company had no healing potions.

To be more accurate, they had twenty. But Thriss had already made it clear that Geneva would not see any of them.

“We’ve distributed half-shares among our officers and veterans. The regular soldiers will have you, and if we can hold for a few days we’ll get another shipment of potions. But it will take time.”

Geneva stared at him. Thriss wasn’t meeting her eyes as he stared at a map on the table. He wasn’t the commander of the company, but he was one of the officers in charge of their battalion. And he had apparently drawn the straw to tell her the bad news.

“You want me to act as a doctor for the entire camp?”

There were over six hundred soldiers in their battalion. Geneva knew not all of them would be injured at once, but—

“I can’t do that. I don’t have the tools for surgery. I need assistants, an operating space, *time*—”

“We’ll clear an area for you to work in. We’ll put you well behind the front lines so don’t worry about that.”

Geneva wasn’t worried about enemy soldiers at the moment. She stared Thriss in the eye.

“I cannot save these soldiers. Not without healing potions.”

“You are all we have.”

Thriss looked at Geneva finally. He met her eyes for a second, and then glanced away. She knew he had a full healing potion in one of the water

flasks at his side. But the regular soldiers wouldn't be getting any potions. Because they were new recruits; expendable.

"Our other battalions can't spare any potions from their supplies. They've been hard pressed too. And the closest force to us is the Burning March 6th Battalion. They've refused to give us any potions as well."

The big man's hand clenched. Geneva just stood and thought.

"If I do this...I can't guarantee I'll save any lives. I can bandage wounds and make tourniquets, but any deep cut, anything worse than a flesh wound—"

"Do your best. That's all we can ask."

Thriss stared back at the map. His voice grew quiet.

"It will get intense tomorrow. We're being sent in to fight against the Magehammer Company. We will flank them. Even if we don't run into their mages, there will be more than enough people for you to work on."

What was she supposed to say to that? What was she supposed to do? Geneva stared helplessly at the man in front of her. He knew she couldn't do this. But he was telling her to do it anyways.

"Can't we wait until we receive supplies?"

"No."

He said it flatly.

"We have to provide support. The battle is not going well. If an entire battalion pulls out of its position, we will give the enemy too much of an advantage."

"So instead you'll send all of these soldiers to their deaths."

"You have your orders. Carry them out."

Geneva stood straight in the tent, feeling as though she'd been slapped. Her voice was taut and cold.

"The gods are dead in this world, Thriss. But tell me, do you believe in immortal souls?"

"Souls?"

The [Sergeant] looked at Geneva. He looked old, and lost, and uncertain.

"I believe I do. I believe in souls, even if there are no gods to judge them."

Geneva nodded slowly. Her own soul ached. But she had no choice.

"In that case, I hope the soldiers who look up to you have mercy on your soul. Because their deaths are on you."

She turned and walked out of the camp tent. Geneva listened to the insects buzzing and the sounds of the jungle at night. She whispered the words as she walked back to her sleeping spot.

“May they have mercy on mine as well.”

The next day, the 4th Battalion of the Raverian Fighters engaged in battle.

Geneva remembered the day as vivid scenes set to the backdrop of screams and blood and gore. Only a few things stood out to her clearly.

She remembered standing at the edge of the camp as Lim, Clara, Fortum, and the other soldiers prepared to enter the fray. She remembered the look in their eyes as they’d stared at her.

“Stay safe, girl.”

Fortum had advised her as he and the other soldiers tightened straps and made sure both armor and weapons were secure. He looked at her seriously.

“You’re all we’ve got. If some fool gets you, we’re all dead men walking. You keep well clear of the fighting.”

“I will. I’ll be waiting in case any of you need me.”

The old man had paused then, and looked at Geneva seriously. There was no blame in his eyes, or fear like there was in Lim’s when the young man looked at her. His voice was soft.

“Don’t blame an old man, but I hope I don’t see you today.”

“I won’t. Stay safe.”

And then they’d left. Geneva had stood in the camp, in the empty tent she’d set up, trembling.

To her surprise, not all the soldiers had been sent out in the first wave. Of course; they had to be rotated and a reserve was necessary to keep the enemy from ambushing the headquarters. So she’d enlisted a few men and women and one Lizardfolk and had them wait near her tent. She needed assistants. Even if they couldn’t help in the surgery, they could at least lift the bodies—

The wounded.

The first soldier arrived almost before Geneva could blink. One second she was trying to sit still, heart racing, waiting for what seemed like eternity, the next she heard the screams.

He'd been hit by an arrow in the first engagement. It had struck him in the leg and by the blood gushing from the wound, it had hit an artery. The soldiers carried him in and Geneva grabbed for bandages.

"Why didn't—"

She almost asked them why they hadn't made a tourniquet. But they were already pushing out the door.

Okay. Severed artery. She had to—

The man gasped, and Geneva's heart stopped. He was awake but barely conscious. The blood loss had already taken its toll and he was limp and his face was pallid.

Move. Geneva tore her eyes away from his face and looked at the arrow. Blood was still oozing from the wound. She had to make a tourniquet.

Geneva wrapped the strip of twisted cloth as tightly around the upper part of his leg as she could. The blood flow cut off. That done, Geneva looked at the arrow.

It was just like the last injury. That was what she told herself. But this time she had to cut into the man's leg. Her angle was bad, and the dagger wasn't nearly as sharp as a scalpel. And when she got into the wound—

"Oh god."

The arrow had indeed sliced through the artery, and Geneva was staring at the hole the extracted arrowhead had made. Somehow, she had to suture that. But she didn't *have* sutures! Okay, first she had to grab the artery, but how could she? She had virtually no surgical tools—

"Forceps."

Geneva fumbled with the wooden ones one of the soldiers had fashioned for her. She fumbled at the exposed artery, trying to grasp it until she succeeded. Desperately, Geneva hung on to that as she reached for a needle and thread.

The artery was severed; the only option she had was to ligate the wound. But doing that with basic thread and a sewing needle filled Geneva with dread. There was just no way she'd be able to do it properly.

But she didn't have a choice. The needle could barely penetrate the artery, and the thread was already sticky with blood. The man was moaning, and Geneva had to adjust every time he moved. Slowly, she got the artery closed, but when she removed the tourniquet, one of her stitches broke. She had to reapply and dig around in the bloody mess again, and then wash the wound and close it up with more stitches.

She took too long. Geneva knew that in hindsight. Two more wounded soldiers had arrived and waited for over half an hour before she decided she'd done all she could. She shouted, and the soldiers came in and out. Geneva's hands were shaking a bit after the operation, but she didn't even have a second to rest.

The second injured person had been hit by a mage blast. And he was a Lizardfolk. Geneva stared at the curling smoke rising from the blackened crater in his side and decided to treat him as if the actual damage had been caused by fire or electricity. Some combination of the two.

She had no real way to treat him. But the worst part was that her patient was conscious. He screamed at her, and screamed harder when she tried to clean the wound with soapy water. He cut her face, and soldiers had to rush in and hold him down.

A skin graft was all she could think of, but Geneva knew she didn't have the time or ability to do that. She could only clean the blackened scales and apply a rudimentary dressing of bandages. The soldiers carried the Lizardman out as he screamed curses at her.

The next patient only needed stitching and bandaging of several deep cuts on his arms. Geneva washed and stitched his skin together as the man yelped and cursed. She gave him garbled instructions to keep the wounds clean and not to strain himself—he stared at her as if she was crazy and told her he was going to be called back into the fighting soon enough.

Geneva paused then to catch her breath and wipe the sweat from her brow. An orange bug tried to land on her bloody hands and more were crawling up the table. She washed them off the table with soapy water and stomped them into the mud at the bottom of her tent. Then she told the soldiers to boil her more water and get her more cloth for bandages.

And then the next patient arrived. He was already dead. Geneva stared at his chest. He wasn't breathing. She confirmed that by testing his pulse and checking to see if he was breathing. He was not. But the cut on his stomach was still leaking blood, and the two soldiers who'd stayed by his side were staring at Geneva with hope in their eyes.

"He's dead. I'm sorry."

They refused to believe. One of the dead man's friends pointed to his hands.

"He's still alive! Look! His hands are moving!"

Geneva looked. The fingers on the dead man's hands were twitching. She'd never seen a corpse do that, but she'd heard stories.

"Muscle spasms. I'm sorry, but there's nothing I can do."

The two stared at her. Geneva called for soldiers to take him out. A fight broke out when they tried to take the dead man's body.

"*Liar! He's not dead! He's not dead!*"

"*Deral! Get away—Deral!*"

Geneva caught a fist as the soldiers fought with the other two. By the time they'd been subdued and the corpse had been taken out, Geneva's cheek was swollen and the ground was muddy.

Then the next patient came in. He was alive and had taken a deep cut to the belly. Geneva had to call more soldiers to help. Three held him down while she had two more help her in the operation. But they were too slow, and too afraid. The man died while they hesitated.

And then the next patient came in. He was missing an eye, and he'd been cut badly. He screamed and thrashed. By this point Geneva was already exhausted and sweat kept running into her eyes. Her helper couldn't even blot it off her head without getting in her way.

In another lifetime, in another world, Geneva's college professor had once tried to make the analogy that surgery was like an orchestra. Each nurse and doctor in the operating room was like a player, and they all had their own part to play. If even one person slipped up, the entire melody, the entire piece fell apart.

He'd made the comparison poorly, and he'd completely flubbed the entire thing when he'd tried to compare general anesthesia to atmospheric lighting. But the analogy had stayed with Geneva.

A surgery was like an orchestra, or a band. Each person had their part to play. True, there were lead players and first violins, but even the most outstanding player could not make music alone. What was a concerto without the accompaniment? What good was a surgeon without the anesthesiologist to monitor the patient's vitals, and her assistants to stop the bleeding and hand her tools?

What could one person do alone? Nothing. And worse, Geneva was still too inexperienced. She had no practice—no real experience with the injuries on the soldiers that were flooding into her tent. She had only studied theory, never tried to repair a collapsed lung or stitch together a burst stomach.

In an operating room, Geneva would have been the least-important member of the team. As a new intern or the youngest doctor, she would have been cutting sutures or cleaning and sterilizing the room before and after the surgery. No—as a student she would have been relegated to observational duty in some schools; just someone that had to keep out of the real doctor’s way at all costs.

But now Geneva found herself leading an orchestra of one, a lone singer on a stage dark with blood, with an audience that was growing with each hour. They screamed her name, and begged her to play music. But she was alone, untrained, unaided.

Yet they screamed her name. So Geneva sang alone. As the screams filled the jungle and the harsh buzzing of flies and larger insects filled the air she cut and bandaged and tried to catch life with her fingers.

It slipped away each time.

After the thirtieth patient, Geneva had to take a break. She staggered outside and threw up. The soldiers watched her anxiously, but Geneva didn’t care. She breathed deeply and drank water, rinsing out her mouth before she drank more, to replenish all the fluids she’d lost.

Her hands were shaking. They were still during the surgery, but now they shook uncontrollably. Geneva sat on a rock for a few seconds, trying to breathe.

They’d all died. Everyone who’d come in to her tent with a serious injury hadn’t gone back out. They’d passed away on that bloody, insect-infested table, screaming and crying and begging her to save them.

Someone else screamed. Geneva looked up and saw a man with no hand. It wasn’t a clean cut that had taken the hand either. It looked like something had *bit* the hand off.

“*Doctor!*”

His friend shouted at Geneva, white-faced. Friends were the worst. Geneva had already banned them from being anywhere near the tent.

Her mind raced. Part of her was already going over the things she’d need to do for a severed limb. It was listing all the things she didn’t have. But it was still possible, and every second she wasted was a second that man was closer to death.

“I can’t do this.”

She whispered the words as she stood up and walked back into the tent. She saved the man’s life, but the flesh around his hand already stank, and

she feared infection would claim his arm. But there was nothing to do.

The next patient had taken three arrows to the legs. One had nicked an artery. He bled out before she could save him.

“More wounded! Where’s the damn [*Doctor*]!?”

Geneva turned, staggering, as she tried to finish her bowl of food. She’d stopped after—she had no idea, really. After a while the soldiers in her tent had turned into a blur.

Soldiers were carrying more wounded into the camp. Geneva looked at some of them and knew they would die. The living fought for space, trying to get their friends into line before the others. Nearly ten wounded this time. Geneva stood up, but then saw something strange.

Two soldiers were dumping a corpse next to the others. But it was not a corpse. Geneva could see it moving, and unlike the soldier who’d had muscle spasms, there was no way to imitate this.

“Wait! He’s not dead!”

Geneva ran forwards. The soldiers turned as she knelt at the side of the moving body. She paused when she saw the injury.

Half of his body had been blown away. A mage’s spell had struck him. Geneva was beginning to notice the signs. And what remained—Geneva blinked at the corpse.

It was a Human’s corpse, but something had happened to it. All the color seemed to have drained out of the skin, and what remained looked—wrong. He almost looked albino, but his hair was a dark red.

The soldier shook his head at Geneva.

“Selphid.”

“What?”

They looked at her as if she was crazy for not knowing. Geneva stared back at them as the hand on the left side of the man’s body raised and lowered oddly, as if he was a puppet that someone was trying to move with only one string.

“They’re body-snatchers. Parasites. They live in corpses and move them about.”

Like brain slugs? Or—they lived *inside* of bodies? Geneva bent down and looked at the destroyed section of the body.

Something was squirming in the insides. Geneva looked closer, and saw where the left side of the corpse had been burned away, something was wriggling in the insides. Something was *living* in the body. Or it had been.

The corpse was clearly trying to move, but it was also clearly malfunctioning, or else the Selphid wasn't able to control it after having half of its own body blown away. The soldier turned away in disgust, and his companion made the same expression.

"Leave it. The Selphids don't have parts like normal folk. If it can't get into another body it'll die."

"But it's injured."

"So? Selphids aren't people."

Geneva could see yellow fluid leaking from the squirming thing inside the body. She took a breath.

"I'm going to operate on it."

"What?"

"It will die without help. And maybe I can transplant it. Put it in line with the others."

The soldiers stared at Geneva, but they did what she said. Geneva stood up, and walked back into her tent.

The living flashed before her eyes, some becoming dead while she stood in her tent, and then sat when her legs started to give out. She could stitch people up, but the deeper wounds still eluded her. Her assistants still couldn't move fast enough, and they kept rotating out of the tent. Some threw up as she was cutting into her victims, and even the bravest of them had to look away at times. Geneva had already gone numb to the smell of blood and feces as the injured and dead voided themselves.

And then the soldiers dumped a corpse on her table. Geneva stared at it until she remembered the Selphid. It was still twitching in the corpse, but weakly. The one eye of the dead man tried to move, but they couldn't fix on her face.

"Can you hear me?"

Geneva spoke to the dead body. The leg kicked feebly. Geneva waited, but the mouth didn't move.

"I am going to operate on you. I will try to save your life. But I need your permission."

There were countless rules regarding malpractice Geneva had been taught in school. If she was in the emergency room in a hospital she would be judged by the professional standards of care and state laws. But here there was no oversight, just herself.

She had a duty to save lives. But she had no idea what Selphids were like. She could kill the creature in the person's body just by slicing him open. So she had to ask.

"I will try to save you, but I have no idea how Selphids work. But I am a [Doctor]. I will do everything I can to keep you alive. But I need your permission."

At last the mouth moved, but only once. The jaw fell open, and Geneva stared at the corpse. The Selphid couldn't speak. She slowly put her hand in the corpses'. It was cold.

"If you want me to operate on you, grab my hand. If not, I will put you with the corpses."

The hand was cold in her grasp. Geneva waited. Ten slow seconds passed, and she began to pull back her hand. Then the fingers *twitched* in her grasp. Geneva jerked away at the strange feeling, and then nodded.

"Okay. Try not to move. If I'm hurting you, let me know."

It was a strange feeling as she cut into the man's skin. She felt like she was doing an autopsy, but this time she was being extremely careful not to thrust in to any part of the body too deeply. She opened the stomach and then saw the Selphid.

It was stretching throughout the dead man's nervous system. A green wriggling mass of tendrils moved weakly as Geneva stared at the body.

The soldiers in the room left. Geneva heard one race out of the tent and throw up as the tendrils tried to reach upwards. She stared. They were wrapped around organs—they seemed to have removed several and the Selphid had infiltrated the dead man's stomach. It was a true parasite.

And it was alive. Geneva had to take hold of herself before her curiosity overwhelmed her. Slowly, she cut until she reached the half of the body that had been blown off.

There. Now she could see what was wrong. The Selphid might have been shielded inside the man's body, but it had still been caught by the explosion. Where the body ended she saw it was bleeding some viscous, orange liquid.

"You're injured. I need to stop the bleeding."

Geneva reached for the Selphid and the needle, but the creature recoiled as she tried to grab it with a forcep. Part of it flowed away, and Geneva realized with a shock that this creature was semi-fluid. Stitches would be as useful as trying to block water with a net.

But the creature was dying, and it was—yes, it was bleeding out. Geneva thought quickly, and then raced out of her tent.

“Get me a piece of metal! A sword, a dagger—something smooth and flat! And a fire!”

When Geneva reentered the tent with a glowing brand of hot iron, the Selphid recoiled. But Geneva set the hot metal down next to the body and explained what she was going to do.

“I need to burn the injuries closed. That’s the only way I can stop the bleeding.”

The Selphid seemed to hesitate. Then it shifted, and Geneva saw several patches of bleeding among the green. She took a deep breath.

“Hold still. This will hurt.”

She had no idea if the Selphid actually had nerves, but she got her answer as she pressed the hot metal down on the extended part of the Selphid, holding it still with a forcep in the other hand. She heard a *shriek*—a high-pitched sound that made her ear wax vibrate, and the Selphid went wild in her grip. But Geneva held on, and when she pulled the burning metal back the green of the Selphid had been discolored and the creature was shaking, but the bleeding had stopped.

The cauterization process was slow and agonizing for the Selphid, but when she was done, the creature lay in the body. It was moving very slowly now, and Geneva wondered if it was allergic to the air, or if it was still dying. The trauma alone might be killing it.

“I need another body.”

Geneva strode out of the tent and walked over to a group of soldiers amassing the dead in a pile to be burnt. The insects were thick, but she found a corpse—a woman who’d died of blood loss from having an artery cut. She told the soldiers to bring it to the tent and then carefully sliced the woman’s stomach open.

“I’m going to pick you up.”

She had to use her hands for that. The forceps weren’t strong enough. The body was warm to the touch as Geneva delved into the organs. The Selphid itself was *warm*. It weakly wrapped around her hands and she lifted it up.

It came out slowly. Pieces of the Selphid were still attached to organs, and Geneva had to pull with more force than she wanted. The creature

screamed, but she eventually pried it loose. Slowly, she placed it in the opening she'd created in the dead woman's stomach and waited.

The Selphid began to move. The bunched up segment of it slowly began to slither deeper into the body, slowly, very slowly. Geneva waited until it was all inside and then she sewed up the opening. And waited.

The body didn't move. After a minute, Geneva realized the Selphid could be dead and she would never know. She waited a while longer, but then she had to turn away.

"Take the body and put it at the back of the line."

She told the soldiers to take away the remains of the first corpse and watched as they brought in another wounded Dullahan. Geneva got back to work.

By the time the corpse came back, it was dark, Geneva was swaying, and the wounded had finally stopped coming in. Everyone who was injured had been treated, or their wounds weren't life threatening, or they'd bled out while waiting.

The corpse was mildly warm to the touch, but it was only from the night air. Geneva hopefully checked the eyes, opening them and flashing lantern light into the empty gaze, but the body did not move. The Selphid was dead.

Exhausted, Geneva set the lantern down and walked away. She was too tired, too drained to even weep. She used the rest of the boiled water to wash herself—although her clothes were ruined—and walked into the camp where the surviving soldiers were eating.

To her surprise, Geneva heard laughter, and even cheering. She collected her food and found that Lim, Clara, and Fortum were all alive. And what was more, they all seemed to be in extremely good cheer.

"Geneva!"

Clara waved her over and edged over on the ground to give her a seat. Geneva sat and listened to the others laughing. She felt like she was in some strange other reality. Why was everyone so happy?

Fortum clapped Lim over the shoulder as he addressed Geneva.

"The kid was a hero! He killed at least eight soldiers in the battle today, and he got through it all with barely a scratch!"

"You'll level tonight, boy!"

Lim blushed as he looked at Geneva. She stared back, her face empty. She'd held a man's intestines in her hand. She'd stared at a hand and knew it was gone. It'd had to be amputated.

“A damn archer was aiming at me, and I’d caught my foot on a body so I couldn’t dodge. He raises his bow and then Lim runs him through from behind! Right through the leather armor! Just like that!”

A gaping hole so wide she could see the table underneath. She was out of time and the man was bleeding. Even if she could stop the bleeding all she could do was sew skin together. His organs were all severed. She watched him choking up blood.

“Geneva? What happened to you?”

Everyone was staring at her. Geneva looked up. They were looking at her face with concern.

“Geneva?”

Slowly, Geneva stared down at her food. She looked at the soldiers, some still covered with blood. The enemy’s blood. The blood of people they’d killed. People they’d injured, like the ones she’d tried to save.

Geneva stood up. Without a word, she walked away. She ate the food quickly by herself and then walked to her sleeping place. She paused to throw up everything she’d eaten, and vomited again and again until she was throwing up nothing but bile. Then she wept, long and hard. Geneva fell into her bedding and only woke when morning came.

[Doctor Level 11!]

[Skill – Injury Sense obtained!]

[Skill – Sterile Equipment obtained!]

Geneva had heard once that a surgeon improved by the number of patients that died under their blade. But this was far too literal. When she woke up and remembered the Skills she’d learned, she didn’t know if she wanted to cry or laugh hysterically.

She had more Skills. And they were valuable. The [Sterile Equipment] Skill would prevent infections, and the other one would allow her to pinpoint bleeding in theory. But at what cost?

They’d all died, all of her serious patients. Maybe she’d saved one or two? But regardless, that was a survival rate of less than 1%. She wasn’t a [Doctor]. She was a glorified coroner who helped kill the living.

Geneva ate in silence with the others this morning. She didn't speak, and the conversation was far more subdued than yesterday. Lim and the others kept glancing at her. Geneva had just finished eating the cheese and bread dipped in soup that tasted like nothing when someone rushed at her.

"Murderer! You let them die!"

A fist struck Geneva on the cheek and then she was lying on the ground. She felt a boot kick her in the chest before someone shouted and the attacker disappeared. Geneva sat up and saw Lim had tackled the soldier who'd hit her. Now the other man's buddies were drawing their weapons, and the people around Geneva were getting to their feet with theirs.

"Put down your weapons!"

Thriss thundered into the fray before anyone could move, face red. He roared at everyone present and threw Lim off the other soldier while he raised his mace. More officers and soldiers joined Thriss, keeping the angry soldiers apart.

"I'll smash the head of anyone that draws blood, my oath on it! We're a battalion—we fight together!"

"Not her!"

Geneva looked around as Clara helped her up. The man who'd struck her was shouting, barely restrained by his fellows. She recognized him. He was the friend of the dead man, the one who he'd insisted was alive. She'd already forgotten the dead man's name.

"She let them die! She's no [Doctor]! She's not even a [Healer]! She just kills anyone she touches! She slices them up and lets them bleed to death!"

The other soldiers stared at Geneva. She couldn't look anyone in the eye. Thriss' face turned even more red, and he roared to cut the other man off.

"Enough! You! You're going in with the first wave. And you—"

Thriss pointed at Geneva. His tone was much softer.

"Get to your tent. The fightin' is going to heat up soon, and we'll need your skills."

He guided her away as the soldiers broke up and another officer took over the shouting. Geneva staggered away as Clara gave her a brief pat on the back. Thriss marched towards her tent—they'd pitched it in another location because the bugs had infested the previous area too badly. Geneva looked up at the [Sergeant]. Her hands were shaking again.

“What he said—”

“He lost his friends. Don’t pay any attention to him.”

Geneva shook her head.

“He was right. I can’t do this. Not alone.”

“There’s no one with a [Healer] class in the battalion. You’ll have to.”

“I *can’t*!”

Geneva stopped in her tracks and shouted at Thriss, ignoring the people who stared.

“I can’t do this alone! I don’t just need another [Doctor]—I need assistants, proper ones! I need people who know how to perform surgeries and don’t throw up *on* my patients. I need surgical tools, or some healing potion for deep injuries. I *can’t* close them on my own.”

Thriss chewed at his lip. Then he shook his head again, reluctantly.

“We have none to spare. We used up a lot of what we had yesterday—and the fighting will only get worse from here. I’ll assign soldiers to you, but I can’t promise they’ll be any better.”

“Then everyone dies, just like that soldier said.”

“I—”

Thriss broke off. He looked at someone behind Geneva, and then she heard a low voice.

“[Doctor].”

Geneva turned. Her heart nearly burst out of her chest.

Someone was standing in front of her. Someone—someone dead. She was one of the soldiers Geneva had tried to save yesterday, the one who’d bled out. But she was dead. She was—

She was the one who Geneva had put the Selphid into.

The woman looked different than she had yesterday. Her skin was totally white now, and she stood awkwardly. The right half of her body sagged, and she moved awkwardly, as if she’d had a stroke. But her left side seemed perfectly able, and she smiled crookedly at Geneva.

Thriss had noted her skin color as well. He put his hand on his sword warily.

“We have no Selphids among this Battalion. Identify yourself.”

The Selphid saluted with one hand. She was armed with a sword, and the dead woman’s armor, the chainmail still covered in dried blood.

“Yes, sir. My name is Okasha. I am a [Rogue], Level 23. I am part of the Burning March 6th Division. My squad was destroyed by a mage spell. I

would rejoin my unit, but my right side is useless. I cannot fight, but I will help the [Doctor].”

“What?”

Geneva stared at the Selphid in the woman’s body. She couldn’t understand.

“You were dead. I saw you. I put you in the other body, but you didn’t move even after I checked again.”

The Selphid smiled.

“I was unconscious. And it takes time for us to assume control of a new form.”

She hadn’t even guessed that might happen. Geneva’s stomach twisted.

“I’m sorry.”

Okasha raised one hand and smiled again.

“I should be the one thanking you. You saved me. I would have died in that body if you hadn’t closed my injuries and put me in a new one.”

Thriss grunted irritably.

“So you can doctor Selphids? Looks like you’ve got a good use, to me. Try to save more of our folk instead of them, though. And here’s your assistant, if you’ll have one of them.”

Geneva looked at Okasha. She bit her lip. The Selphid was clearly disabled or wounded—perhaps permanently if she couldn’t regrow whatever she was missing. But Geneva needed all the help she could get.

“I need an assistant. But I’ll be cutting up bodies and performing surgery. Can you handle that?”

This time even Thriss bared his teeth in a reluctant grin. Okasha laughed.

“I am a Selphid. Bleeding and organs do not scare me.”

Oh. Of course. Thriss left the two as Geneva tried to give Okasha a crash course on the thousands of things she needed to know to be a capable assistant. Okasha listened carefully, nodding. She had a patient personality, and what was even better, she understood when Geneva talked about arteries and veins and bloodflow.

“I know of these things. I have seen them and felt how they move.”

“Really?”

The Selphid nodded. She took a breath—if she didn’t speak she took breaths very rarely, which was unsettling. She also blinked much less than

normal people. She was a creature living in a dead body, but Geneva was fine with that. At least there was life in this corpse.

“I have lived in Dullahan and Lizardfolk bodies as well. I can show you how they live and breathe as well.”

Geneva suddenly realized that she was standing in front of the only person who might know more about the human body than she did. The relief made her almost lightheaded, but then she heard shouting. The soldiers were already heading into battle.

Her face and ribs hurt where she’d been kicked. She was still exhausted, and the dead and the accusations of the soldier still haunted her. But this time she was not alone.

“Apply pressure! I’ll stitch!”

Geneva shouted at Okasha over the man’s screams. The Selphid nodded and hung on to the man’s arm. She was strong—far stronger than normal and while the other soldiers held him down she minimized his blood loss with an iron grip.

The man writhed and screamed, but when Geneva had cut the thread, he was alive and even healthy enough to walk back to camp. That didn’t stop him from trying to take a swing at Geneva, though.

Okasha blocked the strike and sent the man staggering back with a knife-hand to the throat that made him choke. Geneva checked, but his throat was intact. The soldiers roughly dragged her former patient out as she stared at Okasha.

“Don’t hurt patients.”

“Why not? He was striking at you.”

“If that’s the case, try not to *hurt* him. I am a doctor. I have sworn an oath not to inflict needless harm or kill.”

“But you are on a battlefield.”

“Yes. I am.”

Geneva rested her face in her hands. Blood smeared her face before she realized what she was doing. She looked up.

It was no better today. Despite Okasha’s help, she could not save those badly hurt. She was incapable. She couldn’t do blood transfusions and she wasn’t *quick* enough to finish operations before her patients bled out.

But she would save them. Each time one came in, Geneva felt herself go insane. She would save them. She would. She wasn't walking with death anymore. She was wrestling with it.

But she was still losing.

"I can't do this."

They were the same words as yesterday. But the Geneva who uttered them was different. She wasn't desperate and tired any longer; now Okasha was here, she was remembering. It was all so clear now. She had been a fool, trying to adapt modern practices with barbaric tools. She had to go back to another time. Think. She knew some accounts of doctors from World War II. What could she—

The soldiers carrying in the next groaning soldiers were surprised when Geneva thrust her way out of the tent with Okasha behind her. The [Doctor]'s face was grim, but determined. She shook her head at the soldiers.

"Put him down. I'm going to triage first."

She should have done it at the very start. But she'd started on that first patient without even thinking. She was a fool.

Now, though—

"Get me some charcoal and cloth."

She snapped at a soldier as she began to walk the lines of the wounded. There were even more than yesterday. They looked up as she passed, but Geneva didn't meet their eyes. If she did, she would lose heart. Instead, she looked at their injuries.

"White armbands are for priority patients. Use the charcoal and add a marking if they're lower priority."

That was what she informed Okasha as she began to sort the soldiers. She prioritized injuries she could treat that were time-sensitive. Severed arteries, excessive bleeding—

But those with injuries she couldn't mend she left alone. And those who had superficial cuts she added a black line on the cloth she tied to their arms or legs. They didn't understand at first, the soldiers. They stared at her with suspicion, but they began to understand as she brought in the patients she'd marked as priority.

"They are beginning to try to alter their armbands, those who are awake."

Okasha remarked lightly as she handed Geneva one of the sharpened daggers. Geneva grunted and Okasha deftly caught the sweat before it could sting her eyes. The Selphid was competent and deft despite only having one arm, but she had a distinct lack of sympathy for the man who was groaning on the table as Geneva tried to cut a chunk of metal out of his thigh.

“They are trying to erase the black markings. But we shall see if their bands are wet or smudged.”

“Suture.”

The needle was in her hands a second after Geneva said it. The [Doctor] began to stitch rapidly. She could still hear the screams, and what was worse, now she could hear people shouting in anger.

They came for her when she was taking a five minute break. Okasha insisted on it, and Geneva gulped down water and tore into some bread feverishly.

“You!”

A Lizardwoman shouted at Geneva as she advanced on her angrily. The soldiers Thriss had posted with Geneva moved to block her, but the Lizardwoman wasn’t alone. Clara was with her. The other soldier had a dark look on her face.

“Clara? What’s wrong?”

Geneva looked at the woman. Clara pointed.

“Why aren’t you treating Lim!?”

She hadn’t even seen the boy. But he was lying on the ground next to her tent, face pale, gasping. He had a long cut down his sword hand; long, but shallow. Geneva looked back at Clara and shook her head.

“I can’t. He’s not in danger. I have to treat—”

Clara grabbed for Geneva. Okasha blocked her, but the other soldier was screaming at Geneva now. The young woman felt spit hit her face.

“*How dare you!* Lim is your friend! He *saved* you! He was first in line!”

“He isn’t badly hurt. He will wait.”

Geneva’s voice was steel. Her heart was a cold ball. She’d put it away to perform surgery; it was the only way she could stay sane. But now it was melting, growing hotter in her chest.

“You’re a *monster!*”

The Lizardwoman lunged at Geneva and was held back by the soldiers. She struggled in their grip; she was stronger than the other two.

“You’re letting Namass *die*! I saw you—you didn’t even put a band on his arm!”

Geneva remembered the Lizardman. He had been stabbed straight through the gut, but someone had carved upwards and sliced through his organs. There wasn’t anything she could do—nothing that wouldn’t take too long.

She met the Lizardwoman’s eyes.

“I am triaging. I have to prioritize people I can save.”

“That’s evil!”

Clara shouted it at Geneva as Okasha fought to keep her back. Geneva felt her heart grow more painful. The female soldier shouted at Geneva.

“Don’t you care about your friends!? Why aren’t you helping Lim? He’s one of us. He was first. He—”

It was all too much. Geneva heard ringing; saw red. She was grabbing Clara before she knew it, screaming at her at the top of her lungs. The screaming soldiers, the shouting soldiers and those resting in camp—even the insects seemed to fall silent as Geneva gave vent to the fury in her.

“Good? Evil? A *doctor* isn’t any of those things!”

Geneva shouted the words into a pair of scared blue eyes. She shook the other woman hard, grabbing at her with hands still crusted with blood. She pointed at the rows of wounded soldiers.

“I will save everyone I can. I will save *the most people I can*. That is how this works! This isn’t morality! This isn’t choice! This is *medicine*! Now get out of the damn way or help me! I have a job to do.”

She threw Clara aside and stormed towards her tent. Okasha was right behind her. Geneva raised the needle and thread and got to work.

Stitch. Suture. Stop the blood flow here. Bandage. Okasha had learned to tie them properly. Clean the vomit away. Bugs crawling on the feces. Too many. Change locations.

Incision here. Repair this. Cauterize. Amputate. Ignore the screams.

She didn’t even remember falling asleep. She just looked around for the next patient, and there were none. Geneva didn’t remember closing her eyes. She only knew that she fell back and Okasha caught her before she hit the ground.

That night Geneva leveled up again. She gained *six* levels and four different skills. Okasha told her it was practically unheard of, but Geneva had never heard of a modern-day doctor who’d gone through what she had.

Over a hundred and thirty soldiers had passed under her needle and blade yesterday. Of that number, she had saved over two thirds. Twice that number had died over the course of the day. Some had been from her battalion, but Geneva later learned that every group fighting was experiencing potion shortages. They'd sent their wounded to her, sometimes over the course of many miles.

Geneva had learned four skills. Two were merely useful; [Numbing Touch] made people feel less pain and [Flawless Cut] allowed Geneva to make incisions far more easily than before. They were tools to make her better at her job.

But the Skills that changed everything were the combination of [Speed Stitching] and [Enhanced Thread]. With them, Geneva could begin to truly save lives. And she did. The next day, she ate with Okasha by herself and walked towards the tent. This time she reorganized her triage system.

She could suture at a pace three times as fast as before, and with the thread, she could close up even damaged organs. They might still fail, but Geneva was quick enough to stop the blood loss so her patients had a chance. That night she gained only one skill – [Lesser Stamina]. It allowed her to keep going even when night fell.

In the days that followed Geneva gained more skills. She moved faster; began seeing exactly what treatment methods worked best. Okasha found better forceps, and somehow, a few of the soldiers assigned to Geneva learned to bind wounds as well. She rotated them across the lines of wounded, binding injuries and even stitching up wounds while she worked on the most injured.

Sometimes she forgot to eat while she was working, and only a hot meal shoved in front of her face would distract her. Geneva knew she was losing weight, but even when she was sleeping, a scream or cry for her name would rouse her. She couldn't sleep. The faces haunted her. Maybe if there were others it would be different, but she was alone. She couldn't let them die. Any of them.

The soldiers began to level up as [Field Medics] or [Assistants]. Geneva saved more lives. She watched more slip away. But she clung to each thread until it snapped. Death still walked by her side, but slowly, Geneva began to pull ahead.

“More wounded!”

Geneva heard the words and looked up. She was taking a break with Okasha and a few wounded soldiers. There hadn't been any more seriously wounded for a stretch. Now more were coming in, but the soldiers she'd trained were already triaging for her. And she needed a break; she had been working nonstop for three hours and she had to rest or she would make mistakes. Okasha had told her that and because she was right, Geneva had agreed to rest now and then. So Geneva sat and listened to Okasha.

“The Centaur tribe has hit every camp. They launch night raids, sneak attacks...sometimes they strike even if it means taking hundreds of casualties. Just to destroy our potions stock.”

A Dullahan whose head Geneva had stitched up grunted. He cradled his head carefully in his hands as he spoke.

“Bastards. They've got no honor.”

Another Lizardfolk nodded. Non-humans were the ones most willing to talk with Geneva right now. Clara, Lim, Fortum and the others had given her the cold shoulder, and a lot of the Humans thought she was betraying their kind by working on other species first. The Lizardman spat as the severed stump of his tail twitched.

“If we make it out of this mess, you'll bet there will be hell to pay. Even if the Magehammer Company didn't participate in the strikes themselves, they'll be in trouble for letting the Centaur tribe get away with it. No mercenary will work with them.”

“But we are pushing them back. They are outnumbered, and if their mages fall, they will lose their edge.”

Okasha grinned as she said that, but Geneva could only imagine the slaughter. The Selphid stared at the lines of wounded and grinned. The soldiers in this group weren't as badly injured; they had superficial wounds mostly, but Geneva saw one stump she knew she would have to tend to herself.

Two soldiers dumped a body on the ground. Geneva saw a Centaur, half-man, half-horse, bleeding deeply from an injury in the side. Someone had thrown a spear and it had broken off inside of him. He would die soon if she didn't move.

She stood up. Okasha stood too, and Geneva strode towards the Centaur. They had him in the operating tent first. It was a difficult

procedure, cutting the spear out and stopping his bleeding. But they managed it. The worst moment was when the Centaur woke up and realized he was being worked on. He screamed and thrashed and it took eight soldiers to hold him down.

“Easy. Easy. I’m a [Doctor]. I’m going to help you.”

Geneva said the words very slowly to the Centaur, looking into his eyes. His chest heaved; he tried to break free, but slowly he relaxed.

“I won’t hurt you, I swear it.”

He nodded at her, but didn’t relax. He flinched while she extracted the spearhead and only hissed as she sewed his skin together. When it was done Geneva had to help carry him out; he was extraordinarily heavy.

But as they were bringing him to an area that had been cleared for the wounded to lie in, Geneva heard a shout.

“Enemy soldier!”

The people around her raised their weapons. Geneva saw Thriss thrusting people aside. He pointed a finger at the Centaur, and Geneva felt her patient stiffen behind her.

“That’s not one of ours! That’s an enemy!”

He had his mace in his hands. The Centaur raised a hand weakly, but Geneva stood in Thriss’s way. He glared at her.

“Move aside.”

“No. He’s going to die. I am going to treat him.”

Thriss’ jaw clenched.

“He’s an *enemy*. We interrogate him, and we’ll find out what his lot are up to.”

Geneva didn’t move. Thriss tried to shove her aside, but she stepped in his way. She spread her arms.

“I have sworn an oath. If you want him, you have to knock me out. And if you do hurt him, I will not be able to heal any more soldiers.”

She raised her voice so everyone could hear her. Thriss paused as other soldiers looked her way. He gritted his teeth.

“You’re bluffing.”

Geneva met his furious gaze calmly. She spoke as loudly and clearly as she could, knowing every eye was on her.

“If my oath is broken, I will no longer be a [Doctor].”

She felt it was true. And Thriss didn’t have the courage to test her, she knew. Every soldier knew they were out of healing potions; if they were

hurt, Geneva was the only one who could fix them up.

Thriss advanced on Geneva.

“He’s one of the lot who smashed our potions! He’s been shooting at us throughout the battle! Him and all his damn tribe!”

“Then let him go. He can walk—barely.”

Geneva knew the Centaur might not survive the night in the camp, no matter what she said. She stared at Thriss.

“Let him go. I am a [Doctor]. This is my patient.”

Thriss pointed a finger that shook at Geneva.

“I could have you executed for aiding the enemy.”

I will not use my medical knowledge to violate human rights and civil liberties, even under threat.

Geneva gritted her teeth. She stood in front of Thriss and stared the big man down.

“Do it if you must.”

“You swore to obey orders!”

“I answer to a higher oath.”

The [Doctor] and [Sergeant] stared at each other in the center of the camp full of wounded and healing soldiers. He was the first to look away.

“Damn you. Get him out of here!”

The Centaur slowly got to his feet with Okasha’s help. He stumbled, and Geneva insisted on making him a rough crutch before he left. He looked back twice at her. She watched him go. Then she went back and continued to operate.

The next day, Geneva set up her tent further away from the 4th Battalion’s headquarters. And she put up a flag. It had a cross on it, red, painted with the only substance Geneva could use. She hung the flag high in the air on a piece of white cloth. Okasha asked what it meant.

“Healing. Safety.”

“Then why is it red? And why a cross?”

Geneva had no answer for that. But it was a symbol nevertheless. She hung it over her tent, and more than once she found soldiers waving flags with crosses of their own as they brought their friends to the tent. She never asked what side they were on. She just tried to save lives.

Each time someone died, it was like a bit of Geneva went with them. But when she pulled someone back, when they thanked her, a bit of her came back to life as well. She ate and slept and did all the things her body required, but Geneva lived on the operating table. She lived to help other people live.

They all had names, all had families and dreams. They asked her not to let them die, but they couldn't pray because the gods were dead. So Geneva prayed with every cut of her improvised scalpels, and every stitch of her needle. She prayed that she would save them. She prayed to the science she'd been taught, the lessons she tried to remember, and to medicine herself. She prayed that she was making a difference.

They'd just begun operating on a man, when Geneva heard a *thump* and felt the explosion in her bones. She stumbled outside to find the camp was under attack.

A woman hovered in the air, blasting people with fiery orbs that exploded, and tremors that engulfed her victims. She was coming towards the tent.

Geneva grabbed the flag she had planted, and stood in front of the lines of wounded. She held the flag up as the [Mage] approached. The other woman glanced left as an arrow broke against her skin, doing no damage, and pointed. A fiery inferno engulfed the archer who'd fired. Then she saw Geneva.

The [Doctor] stood coughing as the smoke from the fires reached her. Her eyes watered, but she held the flag in front of her. It was a poor shield, made of cloth and blood, but it was all she had.

The woman paused when she saw the flag. Her eyes flicked to the red cross, and then the wounded soldiers who were trying to crawl away or lying comatose on the ground. Then she looked at Geneva.

Their eyes met through the smoke and flame. The woman was smiling in the center of all the death and destruction, untouched. Geneva's heart was pounding; her hands were still covered in the blood of the people she'd tried to save.

Slowly, the [Mage] turned away. She walked into the air, and away from the tent. Geneva collapsed onto the ground. Then she pushed herself back up and ran into the camp. That night she worked late, tending to burn victims and trying to make skin grafts. Many died. But she saved a few.

The last day of the war in the jungle came when Okasha sat next to Geneva at breakfast. The Selphid still hadn't regained use of her right side, and Geneva didn't think she ever would. But the creature was smiling with her body's lips.

"Do you know, the soldiers of both sides know who you are?"

Geneva blinked.

"They do?"

Okasha nodded.

"They call you the Last Light. You shine to them, the dying. Yours is the last face they see, and you drag so many back from the other side. They open their eyes and see you standing in the light."

"That's silly."

"They call you that. And you have saved countless lives. I think that once we are done here, I will join you. Perhaps I can be a [Doctor] too, or at least an [Assistant], even if I only have one arm."

Geneva stared at Okasha.

"There's still fighting going on. This is no time to think about the future."

The Selphid shook her head.

"The Magehammer Company has taken heavy losses. Three battalions managed to flank one of their divisions and we broke through and got their lead [Strategist]. Without him, they'll have to pull back."

"What?"

Someone was cheering in the camp. Geneva looked around. Okasha looked pleased with herself.

"I overheard one of the officers talking. The news is spreading even as we speak. The battle is nearly won."

Soldiers were beginning to celebrate, laughing. Geneva stared at them and just felt empty. She looked at Okasha. The Selphid smiled.

"Perhaps afterwards you can heal those not on a battlefield. There are many people too poor for healing potions or who are hurt in ways that cannot be healed. Maybe—"

"Attack! We're under attack!"

Geneva heard the galloping before she could move. Arrows flew, and suddenly Okasha was falling. An arrow had caught her in the throat.

“Okasha!”

Another arrow flew past Geneva as she caught Okasha. The Selphid wasn't speaking, wasn't moving. Was she dead?

Geneva looked up. Centaurs were running through the camp, shooting wildly. Soldiers fell around them as the Centaurs ran past her. It was another surprise attack on their camp.

One of the Centaurs saw Geneva was still alive. He raised a bow, and hesitated. He stopped and stared at her.

Geneva saw an ugly scar on his side, and looked at a bare-chested young man. He slowly lowered his bow as she looked at him.

Then, he shouted something at the other Centaurs. They paused, and he shouted again, pointing. They whirled, and began to gallop out of the camp.

The Centaur remained behind. He stared at Geneva. Slowly, he walked towards her. He stared down at Okasha, and Geneva stared up. He opened his mouth to speak—

“*Die!*”

The Centaur's head caved in as a mace struck it from the side. Geneva screamed and Thriss pulled his mace back and struck the Centaur again. The young man fell to the ground silently, and the sergeant turned to Geneva.

“You.”

She opened her mouth but he struck her with one hand. She fell face-first to the ground and then heard him roar.

“*Traitor!*”

She tried to stand up, but she couldn't. Something hit her back, so hard the world flashed white. Thriss had struck her with the mace, so hard she felt her spine *cracking*.

“*Traitor!*”

He raised the mace and brought it down on Geneva's back again. She screamed and felt something breaking. She tried to move, but suddenly she couldn't.

Thriss spat on Geneva from above. He raised his mace and gasped as a blade burst through his chest. Okasha *twisted*, and Thriss choked as he fell forwards. The mace fell from his hands and splashed on the muddy ground.

Okasha pulled the arrow from her throat, ignoring the damage it did as it pulled out of her dead skin. Geneva stared up at her.

“I'm dying. My spine is broken.”

She couldn't move. The Selphid stared down at Geneva and said something. Geneva grinned. She couldn't hear anymore, either. No one was screaming. She was the only person in need of medical attention right now, but that was fine. There was no one for her, and she didn't need help anyways. It was growing very dark.

She closed her eyes. Geneva felt everything fade.
She died.

And then she woke up again. Geneva's eyes snapped open and she sat up. She sat up?

She stared around. She was lying on the ground. Water was falling on her face. She looked up. Rain was falling between the cracks of the jungle canopy. It was mixing with Thriss's blood, pelting the corpse of the Centaur.

Slowly, Geneva raised her left hand. She flexed it slowly, and tried to raise her right arm. It wouldn't move. Geneva stared at it.

"I could not repair everything."

A voice whispered in her ears. No—*inside* her ears. Geneva paused. The voice was familiar.

"Okasha?"

Something was wrong. Something was very wrong. Geneva felt something...*twisting* inside of her. Something was *in* her.

"I am here now. I had to bridge the gap to make you move. You will not bleed to death, but you require healing."

Geneva wanted to throw up. Her stomach heaved, but something was in her as well. It held back the reflex.

"You had to live. There was no other way."

It must have only been a few minutes. Geneva stared around the camp. It was in ruins, but she could hear the screaming. Men and women and people of other species were still alive. Some had been hit by arrows; others had been trampled.

And that's when Geneva heard the rumbling, and more shouts. She looked over and saw covered carts rolling slowly through the jungle. Teams of soldiers in bright, untarnished armor marched around the wagons, pointing and shouting as they saw the devastation in the camp.

Geneva began to laugh. She heard a sound in her head.

“What is it?”

“The supply wagons have finally arrived.”

Soldiers were swinging themselves out of the wagons, and those on the ground were rushing towards the fallen. Geneva willed her legs to stand, and they did. But she could feel something else had helped them move.

“I am sorry. This is forbidden, but it was all I could do. But there is no reversing it. I can—”

She could hear them screaming again. Geneva shook her head.

“It doesn’t matter.”

“*What?*”

She willed her feet to walk. They moved reluctantly, but they did move. Geneva stumbled towards the wagon. The soldiers stared at her in shock, but Geneva grabbed as many potions as she could carry.

“Let’s go.”

She strode into the battlefield, leaving Thriss and the dead Centaur behind. The air was hot. Insects crawled over the living and the dead, and screams split the air. Geneva ran with a potion in hand, trying to ignore the agony of her own body, the howling in her mind. People called out her name and she ran towards them, healing their wounds. But it was never enough. Geneva could hear the screaming in her head. One more. She turned over bodies, staring at arrows, feeling for a pulse.

One more. There had to be one more. A voice was speaking to her, and someone was trying to make her rest. Geneva ignored it. One more. She had to find—

One more. But every face she turned over was blank and staring. Geneva ran on. She was so tired. She had to sleep.

Slowly, the [Doctor] fell to her knees. Mud and blood ran together as she fell into it. Geneva stared ahead, searching for bodies, but now she could no longer move. Slowly, her eyes closed.

The young woman lay still on the ground. Soldiers ran around her, tending to the wounded. Geneva slept. For once, she couldn’t hear the screams.

It was pleasant.

Quiet.

She slept, as the Selphid in her body made her walk to a safe place and lie down. In the jungle, the Magehammer Company retreated and ceded the

rights to the mine to the Burning March company. The Ravarian Fighters reformed their shattered battalions and there was peace.

In one small place. But Baleros bled, and the jungles ran with blood which fed the insects. There was always war. War, and more war. But word spread from soldier to soldier as mercenaries travelled and rumors flew like birds. They spoke of a red cross, and a class that saved lives rather than took them. They told legends that the soldiers clung to in hope as they marched to war or lay dying. The soldiers spoke of a woman who could save lives, of a place that took no sides. They told stories about her. A healer, a savior.

A [Doctor].

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Pawn knew he had to return to the Hive after leaving the inn. He knew that. But he found the food Lyonette had given him was disagreeing with his stomach a bit. It must have been the eggs. Antinium didn't usually experience food poisoning, but that didn't mean they couldn't get sick.

Therefore, Pawn decided that before he went back into the Hive and talked to Revalantor Klbkch, he should walk around the city for a while. So his steps slowed, and Pawn took the time to walk down side streets, peek down alleyways he'd never entered before, and admire the sights. He was just doing it for his stomach, but really, it was very important to look around. There were so many things Pawn would miss if he hurried!

For instance, had he ever really appreciated the wonders of the hamburger flipping Drake who stood on the side of the street, calling out to potential customers? The craze over the new food had swept through the city and burned itself out—now people were just as likely to go to the other hot food stands at this time of night. And yet, there was something graceful about the way the yellow-scaled Drake flipped the sizzling patties of meat.

Pawn inhaled the scent, along with the crisp fresh winter air. Yes, the above world was not as familiar as the Hive, but there was beauty in it he had never seen below. Why did no one ever appreciate it? Why hadn't he? But it occurred to him that when he had been a nameless Worker, not once had he ever really stopped to stare up at the stars.

The Antinium looked up. The sky was dark and black—it was cloudy.
“Ah.”

After a moment, Pawn walked on. He took side alleys, detours—he had no fear of being mugged, and indeed the one skulking shape he encountered in a rougher part of the city retreated when it saw Pawn coming its way. No robber wanted to arouse the wrath of the Antinium, and crime wasn't very profitable in a city where the Antinium lived in any case. Something about an Antinium Soldier *smashing* through a wooden door as ten more burrowed out of the ground tended to discourage thieves and muggers.

Perhaps Pawn should look for crime, though. Wasn't that a useful pursuit? He could chase after the thieves, hit them, maybe. Or just warn them verbally?

Pawn sighed. He knew what he was doing. He was procrastinating, avoiding doing what he needed to do. It was the first time he'd ever done it, really. It wasn't the most comfortable of feelings; he knew he had to act, yet he was caught in indecisiveness, holding himself back. No, it wasn't comfortable at all. But he still hesitated. He did not want to talk to Revalantor Klbkch.

Because he was afraid.

When had he ever been afraid? Not really...ever. Only once, perhaps. Pawn could remember being afraid when Ksmvr came for him and questioned him. Then he had been terrified. And he had been afraid when he'd heard the undead were attacking Liscor and he'd feared for Erin's life.

Twice, then. But beyond that? What about when he'd been a simple Worker?

No. Never. Pawn hadn't been afraid. He hadn't been much of anything, really. He'd just been, the same way as a tool was. But now he felt, and what he felt was fear.

He did not like Klbkch. Pawn knew that the former Prognugator was considered well-liked even by the usually hostile residents of the city. He had friends among the Watch, and he was a familiar face, even if all the Antinium looked the same. Pawn had seen the Prognugator—every member of the Hive had at some point. The Prognugator was old, far older than anyone but the Queen, he commanded them in battle and oversaw them as they worked. He slew Aberrations, too. He was known. And one thing Pawn knew about him was that Klbkch didn't seem to like any of the Workers or Soldiers.

The Queen did. They were her creations, her children, after all. Pawn had stood before her once, and though she had questioned him and the words had shattered his spirit, he had known that she cared for him in her own way. She would not hesitate to use him for the Hive, but he was part of her Hive, and thus she cared for him if not as one individual, then as a part of herself. That was reassuring, and all he had expected of her. But Klbkch?

No. He had friends. Relc, the angry Drake. And Pawn knew he liked Erin. But *everyone* liked Erin. Pawn liked Erin, but he could not bring himself to like either Ksmvr or Klbkch. And he was fairly certain that the Revalantor had the same opinion of him.

It wasn't anything the two had ever said. And Klbkch hadn't ever done anything to Pawn. He hadn't ripped off Pawn's antennae and cut off his

fingers and parts of his arm while questioning him for instance. But Pawn still didn't like him.

And he was afraid of what Klbkch would say. Ksmvr had been ruthless, but he had been new to his role, and inexperienced. It had given Pawn the courage to stand up to him, later. But Klbkch was ancient. If the Antinium had legends, he would have been one. But they had no stories, no individuals to name and speak of. There was only the Queen, and Klbkch, the Prognugator.

That was how it had always been.

Pawn stopped in the snowy street in front of the entrance to the Hive. He stared down at the dark entrance into the ground. The dark didn't scare him, nor did the underground. But the hole still looked ominous. Pawn took a deep breath, and then another one. And another one.

He didn't want to do this. But he had to. If only Erin had been there—but there had only been Lyonette. Erin would have helped him. She would have said something reassuring that would have made Pawn not afraid.

Like what? Pawn thought about this.

"Ah. 'You can do it, Pawn! If Klbkch gives you any trouble, kick him in the nuts! Do Antinium even have nuts?'"

A passing Drake [Guardswoman] walking down the street gave Pawn a look of deep suspicion. He dropped the falsetto and nodded to her politely. After a moment she hurried on her way.

"I am not sure if Klbkch eats nuts. I believe they may contain gluten. I will inquire, however."

"You do that. Good luck, Pawn!"

"Thank you."

That made Pawn feel a bit better, although he still didn't understand the nuts reference. He took another breath, and then marched into the Hive. He could do this. He was Pawn. If he reached the end of the chess board he could become a Queen! Or a bishop. Or knight. Queen was the optimal piece to play, but under certain situations it might be better to choose knight.

From street level in Liscor, descending into the Antinium Hive looked ridiculously easy. There were no noticeable guards, and the dirt was sloped for easy entry. But that was an illusion.

About ten steps into the darkness below, Pawn glanced left and right. The silent Soldiers standing in their alcoves in the wall watched him pass

without moving a muscle. On the other hand, if he'd been anyone but an Antinium, they would have immediately apprehended him, and his survival would have been contingent on how much of a fight he put up. The Antinium had made many concessions to live in Liscor, but they did not suffer intrusion lightly.

As always, the Soldiers looked identical as they stood at the ready, even to Pawn. He could identify some other workers by the scratches on their chitin, or their jobs, but the Soldiers were one alien mass to Pawn. Workers did not talk to Soldiers, and Soldiers did not work with Workers unless there was some construction that needed their cooperation. Or if they trampled a Worker by accident.

But today Pawn was feeling reckless. He stopped and looked at one of the Soldiers. The Antinium was head and shoulders taller than Pawn and far broader, too. Pawn looked at his stub-like fingers, designed to pierce an enemy's skin and let the Soldier bash his opponent into submission. But they were Antinium, weren't they?

"Ah, good evening."

The Soldier stared at Pawn. Pawn stared back uncomfortably. What was he doing?

Exchanging pleasantries. That was it. What came next?

"Rather cold outside, isn't it? I hope you are all warm?"

The Soldiers didn't respond. They couldn't—they couldn't speak. But they made no move either. They just stared at him. But all of them were staring, now.

After a second, Pawn continued walking. He felt the gaze of the Soldiers on his back as he left, though. And his mind was in turmoil. Pawn entered the flow of other Workers and groups of Soldiers and descended into the hive, wondering. Why had he done that? It was stupid. Had he expected a response? No, of course not. Then why had he done that?

Maybe because it was something Erin would do. Something she'd done. She'd asked a Worker his name, and treated him as if he weren't just one of many.

Pawn sighed, and the Workers around him stiffened for a second as he walked through the shifting mass in the tunnels. That was stupid. He wasn't Erin. And Soldiers couldn't be Individual. He'd tested them with Klbkch. They took longer to respond to being questioned. And they didn't react to

being asked who they were and what their names were in the same way. But when they did—

The Worker shuddered as he remembered Klbkch whirling, cutting, limbs and green gore flying everywhere. No. Soldiers could not be Individual. It didn't work for them. It barely worked for Workers without Erin.

As Pawn walked through the endless traffic of the Hive, the Workers around him slowly began to peel off, taking other corridors elsewhere in the Hive. In the end, Pawn reached his destination—a small room at the end of a dirt corridor—alone. He stared into the room and saw a seated Antinium, a being with two arms and slim frame instead of the normal four arms and bulkier body.

Klbkch.

Pawn wasn't ready to talk yet. He wasn't ready—but it was too late. There were no doors in the Hive except where it was crucial to maintain an airtight environment. Klbkch looked up as he noticed Pawn standing in the hallway.

“Enter.”

Immediately, Pawn's legs obeyed the order. The Worker mechanically entered the room and stood before Klbkch. The Revalantor and Prognugator of Liscor's Hive looked up at Pawn from the small wooden desk he sat at, expressionless. The two swords of his station hung at his side; the Antinium did not take them off even in the Hive. Pawn found his eyes drawn to the blades; they were the same ones that had sliced off his limbs.

“Pawn. Is there something you need to bring to my attention?”

“Um.”

Pawn stared at Klbkch, feeling his heart racing frantically. His mind felt blank. He didn't know what to say. But now Klbkch was staring at him, and he had to say *something*. What would Erin say?

“Yes. No? I have a lot to say. About classes. Mine, that is.”

“Indeed?”

Klbkch shifted in his seat. He looked at Pawn—coldly. Yes, it was a cold look. The Antinium didn't have many expressions, but Pawn could tell he wasn't happy.

“Have you received a different class? Or leveled up since we last spoke?”

The Queen had told Pawn to report any changes in his level or class to Klbkch. The Revalantor was in charge of monitoring the new Individuals. Pawn hesitated. He had to tell the truth. But he really didn't want to. Maybe he could work up to it?

"Yes, I have news. But I ah, also came to ask about it. News, that is."

"News? What are you referring to?"

"Erin."

Pawn didn't know what he was saying. Why was he asking the Revalantor for information? But he did want to know.

"Is she well? I went to her inn today, but the girl living there told me that Erin was missing. Lost. In a Human city?"

Klbkch nodded reluctantly.

"That is so. She is well, and Ryoka Griffin is with her. She cannot return yet due to the Goblin presence in the region, but she is safe."

"I see. I...see. That is good."

"It is acceptable. Now, inform me of the new class or level you have obtained."

Klbkch was staring hard at Pawn. The Worker felt like sweating, even though the Antinium didn't sweat. Or maybe he just felt like excreting liquids.

"I have...gained a new class. A while ago, in fact."

"Indeed? Why did you not report this to me at once?"

Klbkch's tone grew colder, if that was even possible. Pawn lowered his head.

"I was unsure of the nature of the class. I received it after a conversation with Erin Solstice, and I have been unable to discern the nature of either the Class or Skill I received."

The Revalantor shook his head slightly.

"Erin. Of course. What Class did you receive after speaking with her?"

"[Acolyte]."

The Revalantor paused. Pawn could see him visibly thinking. Then the other Antinium shook his head.

"I am unfamiliar with the class, as well as the word."

"As am I. I was hoping you could shed light upon the meaning of the class."

"I see."

Klbkch did not rise from his seat, but he shifted ever so slightly.

“You said you obtained this class after speaking with Erin? What was the context of your discussion?”

“It was...”

Pawn hesitated. It had been just after his questioning by the Queen. He had been in turmoil, asking about the dead Workers. His friends. Erin had comforted him, given him hope. But he didn’t want to tell Klbkch that. Instead, Pawn chose the simplest answer.

“We talked about religion. And I believe my class pertains to Gods.”

Instantly, the Antinium seated in front of Pawn froze. His entire body grew still, and Pawn could sense the emotions whirling in Klbkch. But the Revalantor didn’t do anything. Instead, after a minute he looked back up at Pawn as if nothing had happened.

“Gods?”

“Yes.”

“Intriguing. Do you refer to the dead gods of ages past?”

“No, a new God. A living one.”

There it was again. Klbkch froze, only for a shorter period. Pawn watched him carefully.

“Revalantor Klbkch, do you know anything of Gods? I had a discussion with Erin Solstice about them, and she informed me of a being known as a God. In the past, people prayed to them. And they possess powers similar to magic. But...”

His voice trailed off. Klbkch was staring at Pawn, but it was as if he was looking straight through him. Suddenly, the Revalantor’s body was tensed, and his expression—

“Revalantor Klbkch?”

The other Antinium slowly shook his head.

“I know nothing of Gods. But you said that after you talked with Erin, you gained the [Acolyte] class?”

“Yes. Because I...believed in Gods. Or so it seems.”

Klbkch stared at Pawn. The Worker shifted uncomfortably.

“You do not know what this means? I received the Skill of [Prayer] for reaching the first level in my class.”

“I see.”

The Revalantor nodded once, twice. He paused, and then looked up at Pawn and shook his head slowly.

“This class is a mystery to me. I know of Gods, but only those who are dead. It would appear your class is an enigma.”

“So it would appear.”

“Yes. But I have noted its occurrence. You said you were Level 1 in the [Acolyte] class?”

“That is so.”

“Very well. You may return to your quarters.”

Pawn stared at Klbkch for a few more seconds, disappointed. He felt... let down. He'd expected the Revalantor to say something, or reveal something to him about the class that Pawn hadn't known. At the very least, he'd expected Klbkch to be disapproving, but this?

It was almost as if Klbkch was hiding something. But whatever it was, Pawn didn't expect Klbkch to confide in him. Reluctantly, he turned to go.

No answers here. What should he do next? Pawn stopped at the doorway, thinking. Only Erin could help him after all. Did Klbkch know when she would return?

“Revalantor Klbkch? May I ask if you know anything of when Erin will ret—”

Pawn turned and saw Klbkch, frozen in place with one sword raised to cut him down. The two Antinium stared at each other. If they were Human, perhaps Klbkch might have pretended it was a joke. Laughed, maybe, and tried to play it off. But the Antinium were different. Klbkch made no pretense; he lifted his sword and spoke calmly.

“If you are loyal to the Hive, do not move. You will be dead quickly.”

“What are you doing?”

Pawn backed away from Klbkch. The Revalantor was advancing on him—cautiously. Both of his silvery swords were aimed at Pawn, and the Worker knew that Klbkch could cut him into pieces in a second. But why?

“Revalantor Klbkch, have I offended you in some way? If so, I—”

“Silence.”

There was quiet menace in the Revalantor's voice. Normally such an instruction would have made Pawn shut up, but he knew he was about to die either way. Panicked, Pawn raised his hands as he retreated from Klbkch.

“I have done nothing wrong. I am not an Aberration! I—”

Klbkch shook his head.

“You know of Gods. You must die.”

He said it as if it were a simple truth. But Pawn still didn't understand. He backed up again and felt his back hit the dirt wall.

"I do not understand. Revalantor Klbkch, if I have erred please allow me to correct my mistake."

"The only correction can come from your death. No one may know of Gods."

Klkbch walked forwards, the two deadly blades in his hand. For a second Pawn considered running, but he knew he would be dead in an instant if he did. The only reason he hadn't died yet was—

Was...?

Klkbch was hesitating. He was staring at Pawn as if he didn't know where to cut. Maybe because he wasn't sure? If that was the case...Pawn's mouth worked with desperation.

"You should not kill me. Knowing of Gods is not dangerous to the Hive."

"It is."

"Erin told me of Gods. Will you kill her, too?"

The other Antinium hesitated as he lifted a sword up. Pawn stared at the deadly edge as it poised to come down.

"Erin is different. But you—you are expendable."

That was true. Pawn knew it. But still. He stared upwards at the blade, and then down at the ground. He couldn't close his eyes, no matter how hard he wanted to. His voice was quiet, yet his pulse thundered.

"Please. I do not wish to die."

He could see only Klkbch's legs. Pawn kept his head bowed, trembling. Waiting. Would it hurt? Would he feel it, or would his next thoughts be when he was in—

Heaven.

Time seemed to slow for Pawn as that thought emerged. He imagined it, a place without pain or fear. A place where he was welcomed; a place to be. But then he thought of God and wondered.

He wanted it. But he didn't. And as he thought of that, Pawn remembered Erin and wondered what she would do when she found out he was dead. And in that moment he didn't think of heaven. He wanted to live, still. In the second before he died, Pawn whispered the word. His desire.

A prayer.

"Please."

He felt nothing. Pawn kept his head bowed, and then sensed it. Movement. Slow—and then a noise. He heard the sound of metal on metal and dared to open his eyes. Klbkch was sheathing his swords.

The Revalantor of the Antinium stared down at Pawn. He looked uncertain. Old. Tired. But his voice was like cold steel as he spoke.

“Here is what will happen. You will not mention Gods or your class or Skills to anyone. And you will not worship or interact with this one in any way. Is that clear?”

Pawn could barely speak. He looked at the Revalantor, but instead of obedience, his first instinct was to question. He had to know.

“Why? Why are Gods not to be spoken of?”

Klbkch shook his head.

“That information is secret. You do not need to know it.”

“But what did I do? Why is knowing of Gods important? All know of the dead Gods—”

Pawn only saw a blur, and then he felt himself being *crushed* against the wall. Klbkch held him with one hand while the other one held a sheathed sword an inch away from Pawn’s eye. There was no mercy in the other Antinium’s gaze, just cold, focused anger.

“I will repeat myself once: you do not need to know why. You are a Worker; you *will* obey.”

Pawn tried to make a sound; it was only a gurgle. Klbkch held him in place until Pawn was starting to see blackness around his vision, and then he let go. Pawn gasped as Klbkch stepped back and sheathed his sword again.

“You are forbidden from discussing God, your class, or any similar subjects with any Workers or Individuals. Is that understood?”

“Perfectly.”

The words felt bitter as they left Pawn’s mouth, like how the food sometimes tasted if the Worker’s food had included more semi-rotten ingredients than normal. Klbkch stared at Pawn and then nodded curtly.

“Good. Leave. I will summon you at a later date to address this.”

Without another word, the Revalantor turned and strode off through the tunnels. Pawn watched him go. He had no idea what had happened, what to think. But he was alive. He was—

Alive.

Twenty minutes later, Pawn had finally regained enough of himself to walk away from Klbkch's quarters, in case the Antinium returned. He walked slowly through the Hive, ignoring how his pace slowed up countless Workers and Soldiers behind him. He had to think.

What had happened? What had he said that had upset Klbkch so? Why—why was mentioning Gods so wrong?

What was wrong with a God?

Pawn walked along, kicking at the ground. He didn't know where he was going. He was upset and confused and—

Why had Klbkch acted the way he had? Why had he nearly *killed* Pawn? Over what? Over Gods?

No...knowing that there *were* Gods, not just dead ones. But even that made no sense. A God was a good thing. Erin had explained it. Gods helped. Gods made heaven and that meant...

Pawn turned and followed another Worker at random. He didn't even care where he was going. What was Klbkch going to say to the Queen? Would she summon him? Or just have him killed? For knowing of Gods?

Why? It wasn't fair. It wasn't right. Klbkch hadn't asked about the God, didn't know anything—or if he did, he hadn't explained.

Why would he hate Gods? Or a God? Why hate a God? That made no sense.

It was a God. God was God. Gods. Heaven. Gods and heaven and forgiveness and sin. How could anyone just turn their back on that? Or just ignore?

Pawn stopped at the entrance to a large room. He faintly detected the unmistakable aroma of the Hive's food. Oh. Of course. It was meal time for some shift of Workers. He didn't really want to eat, but maybe the noxious food would calm him down. He had to do something, whether it was walk or eat...

Automatically, Pawn walked into the large room. He got into line and then paused. The Worker in front of him was quite large. And the room was a bit bigger than normal. He stared up at the broad back in front of him. And up...and up...at the head of the Soldier...

Pawn froze. He stared around the room. The line in front of him wasn't moving, and no one in the room was either. Soldiers, hundreds of them, sat

or stood, all turned towards Pawn.

Staring at him.

The room was full of Soldiers. Soldiers, and a dozen Workers who were serving food to them in huge, deep containers three times as large as those given to Workers. But even they had paused in the act of ladling the soupy mush into the Soldiers' bowls.

Everyone was staring at Pawn. He felt hot, then cold. And afraid and—He'd gone the wrong way. He'd taken the wrong turn, because he was not supposed to be here. Oh, no. Not at all.

Pawn had walked into the Soldier's mess room. Not the Workers'.

In the complete stillness, Pawn looked around. Everyone was still staring at him. All the Soldiers in line were looking at him and he couldn't read their expressions. Pawn felt a cold knot of fear in his stomach.

He shouldn't be here. Pawn turned to go, and then hesitated.

Why should he go? He didn't belong here, true, but no one was kicking him out. And he was an Individual, wasn't he? Couldn't he stay here? What would happen if he did? Would Klbkch hunt him down and kill him?

Slowly, cautiously, Pawn stepped back into line. He stared at the Soldier in front of him, almost daring the huge Antinium to do anything. The Soldier stared back, and then slowly turned forwards. The Soldier in front of him did the same.

As one, the room slowly moved back into motion. The Workers continued serving food, the Soldiers filed forwards, and Pawn found himself in line, holding a huge and heavy container. He wasn't even hungry, but he was committed now, and found himself standing in front of a Worker with a huge ladle who dumped a large amount of orange-brown stuff into his bowl. It looked like the food Workers got, but there was a lot more of it.

"Ah. Thank you.."

The Worker stared at Pawn. Pawn stared back. Then he shuffled forwards and a Soldier took his place.

What next? Now Pawn supposed he had to eat the horrible food, all of it. He stared around the room and noticed something else that was different about this room. All the Soldiers weren't eating while standing like the Workers. No, instead they were sitting!

Each Soldier sat on a mound of dirt and balanced their food receptacles in the small hollowed-out mounds of the dirt table in front of them. Pawn

stared, amazed. They had *benches* and *tables*! True, they were just crude mounds of dirt packed together until it was hard as stone, but still!

Pawn quickly realized why the Soldiers had tables; they had to. Their basins of food were too deep to really eat from without a stable surface, and the Soldiers' clumsier appendages couldn't balance their containers as easily.

Indeed, now that Pawn looked, the Soldiers ate far differently from the Workers. Instead of efficiently scooping food into their mouths they stuck their heads in the containers, or awkwardly lifted the muck up. They just didn't have the same manual dexterity, and that meant there was a lot more mess on the ground.

Pawn sat at a table with two other Soldiers and looked around. There were hundreds of Soldiers in this room, all eating feverishly. He was so preoccupied with staring that he completely forgot his own food, until he saw one Soldier exiting the food line.

Maybe the Soldier was tired or distracted—Pawn kept thinking the other Soldiers were staring at him, but whenever he looked around he just saw them engrossed in feeding. But this Soldier failed to notice some fallen food slopped on the ground as he carefully held his own bowl of dinner. His foot trod down on the slimy patch and he slipped.

Pawn saw the Soldier try to regain his balance, but it was too late. The Soldier didn't fully face-plant, but he collapsed forwards and all of his meal spilled out of the bowl in front of him. Instantly, the Soldier righted himself and scurried forwards, but the damage was done.

The Worker saw the Soldier desperately try to push the spilled slop back into the container, but he got as much dirt as food in as anything else. The resulting mash was...even more disgusting than it had been, but the Soldier righted his container and walked over to a table. He began to eat as if there was nothing wrong. But there was.

The Soldier couldn't have been happy with the dirt-infused food. Pawn knew that. He and the Soldiers might differ in size, but they were still based off the same shape. He knew how appalling the food was *without* adding anything else to it.

And yet, the Soldier made no effort to go back into line. Nor did Pawn really expect him to; that would have been...not against the rules, but it would have been unusual. No non-Individual would have done something like that, so the Soldier would just eat his dirty food in silence.

That wasn't right. Pawn stood up. He didn't realize what he was doing at first, but as he approached the unfortunate Soldier, his own bowl in hands, he knew. The Soldier looked up and froze as Pawn came over to his table.

Pawn cleared his throat awkwardly. He didn't know—he could sense the eyes of everyone in the room on him again. But he knew what he wanted to say, so he said that.

“Here. I don't need mine.”

The Soldier stared at Pawn as the Worker thrust the bowl of food at him. He stared at the bowl, and at Pawn.

“Take it.”

Slowly, the Soldier shoved his bowl aside. He reached up, but his fingers were clumsier. Pawn carefully put the bowl in front of him. The Soldier stared at the food, and then at Pawn.

Then he began to eat. Cautiously, carefully. As if every bit of this new mush was ten times better than the dirty stuff in his bowl. Which, to be fair, it wasn't. It was only a bit more palatable, but the Soldier ate and Pawn felt...

Better. Just a bit.

After that, Pawn just sat at the table while the Soldiers ate. He tried to focus on them, rather than think. It was almost peaceful, not having to do anything. And Pawn was so tired of—

The last Soldier finished eating from his bowl and stopped. Instantly, all the Soldiers stood up as one. Pawn jerked in surprise, but the Soldiers just walked towards the entrance of the meal hall. They put their bowls on a long shelf of dirt as they passed, ready to be reused as they filed out of the room.

Oh. Of course. They were done with their meal and leaving. Pawn stood up and followed them out, noting a new group of Soldiers were coming in. He left with the first group, and because he didn't feel comfortable following the Soldiers any more, he began walking back to his sleeping area.

It was time to sleep. Pawn found his spot, looked around, and saw countless other Workers already sleeping in their dirt cubicles. He stared at his hands as he made himself comfortable in his spot.

This day was confusing. He'd been afraid at first, and then nearly killed when he'd spoken to Klbkch. Pawn still didn't know why, but he was afraid

to find out. Afraid—and yet, he wanted to know now. Klbkch knew something about Gods, and Pawn wanted, no, *needed* to know. He would find out.

And the Soldiers? Pawn thought of the Soldiers. He didn't know what to think about that. It was just a small part of a long day. And yet he was still smiling a tiny bit as he fell asleep.

The next day, Pawn woke up as he felt Klbkch summon him to his room. It wasn't an actual voice in his mind—it was more like a feeling, strong as certainty. It made Pawn rise before the other Workers and walk through the tunnels to Klbkch's quarters before he'd even eaten.

"I am here, Revalantor."

"Come in and sit."

Klbkch had placed a second seat in the room. He sat in his own chair, twin blades sheathed as he watched Pawn sit. He wasted no time on greetings or small talk—the Antinium just leaned forwards and spoke.

"I have consulted with the Queen on this matter. You will not be killed—immediately. But if there are any changes in your physical form or actions which may harm the Hive, you will be immediately killed. Is that clear?"

"Yes."

Pawn stared at Klbkch, confused but determined to listen and make sense of things. Klbkch held his gaze for a few more moments and then nodded.

"Now. Explain this God to me."

"What?"

"Explain it. All of it. What Erin said about this God, word for word. I want to know its history, forces, motivations—everything."

That was how Pawn found himself trying to tell Klbkch the same story Erin had told him. He tried to start with the same miracles she'd begun with, a God that created the world and made people in his image while he watched over them, but he kept on getting interrupted by Klbkch.

"There are no mentions of multiple Gods?"

"None. As I was saying, after he created the world, he rested for—"

"And it is a he? This God has a gender?"

Pawn *clicked* his mandibles together irritably. He hadn't had breakfast, and he was hungry, even for his daily rations. Klbkch kept interrupting him before he got to the important parts, too. Who cared about gender?

"...That was how Erin described him, although she said that God may not have a gender."

"Why say 'he', then?"

"She said 'it' sounds too weird."

"Hmm. Does it have a physical presence?"

"In a sense. It—he—works through chosen Humans."

"I am familiar with the [Priest] class. In any other ways?"

"Ah...he sent his son to earth. And his son is divine as he is."

"His son?"

Klbkch stared at Pawn so hard that the Worker felt uncomfortable. Why did Klbkch care so much about these details?

"Yes. God had a son. He was named Jesus of Naz—"

"Explain to me how a God has a son. Would that not also make him a God?"

"He is...part-God, or so I believe. But there is only one God in that sense, or so Erin said."

She mentioned other Gods, but Pawn felt it wise not to mention that just yet. Klbkch tapped his chin with his finger.

"I feel there is something I have missed. I shall re-clarify. There is only one God, correct?"

"True."

"But he has a son."

"Yes."

"Whom he incarnated as a physical manifestation on earth."

"Born of a Human. He was Human."

"But he is also part God?"

"...I believe so."

"That makes no sense."

It didn't. Or rather, it did and Pawn understood it in his own way, but he knew he couldn't explain that to Klbkch. He tried to shift the conversation away from this issue and get to the important part.

"He is dead, in any case. He is now in Heaven, with God. That is what Erin told me."

"I see. So in any case, there is only one God."

“Yes, but in Heaven—”

Once again, Klbkch cut Pawn off.

“So, you are absolutely sure that this God is not present in the world at this moment?”

Pawn couldn't really scowl, but he grew agitated and let his voice reflect that.

“I am *sure*.”

“Very well. Now, where did this son of God incarnate? Do you know the geographical location?”

“Yes. Yes I do. He was born in Jerusalem, a small town in the nation of Rome. This was at the time when—”

“Rome? Jerusalem? Where are these places located? Which continent?”

“These are locations and names from where Erin comes from.”

It was as if Klbkch was listening to something completely different than Pawn. The instant Pawn said that, he relaxed and seemed almost relieved.

“I see. I see.”

Pawn stared at him, nonplussed.

“As I was saying, the Human woman Mary was pregnant, and she was due to give birth—”

“I do not need to hear the rest of the story at this moment.”

It was like being slapped repeatedly. Pawn opened his mandibles, and then closed them. He was annoyed, and so he interrupted Klbkch before the Revalantor could speak.

“How is any of this important, Revalantor Klbkch? Why are Gods an issue that requires so much attention?”

Klbkch paused.

“That is none of your concern. It is a secret.”

“I would like to know it.”

“You will not be told. Enough. My next question—”

“I should know. If I do not, I may err accidentally.”

Pawn held Klbkch's gaze as the other Antinium looked up and stared at him. After a second, the Revalantor seemed to come to a decision.

“All you need to know is that the existence of a God is tied to the Antinium's existence on the continent of Rhir. Although the Antinium have changed since then, my original task as a Centenium relates directly to Gods in particular. It supersedes all other orders; hence, my inquiry. That is all.”

Pawn felt as though he should drop his jaw like he had seen Erin do now and then.

“Centenium? I am not familiar with that role. What are—”

“Enough.”

Klbgkch stopped Pawn with one hand. He considered, clicking his mandibles together lightly as Pawn shifted impatiently in his seat. At last, Klbgkch nodded.

“I have ascertained that this God is not similar to...it is not of immediate concern.”

“Meaning what?”

“I am not sure. But as its existence is known only to Erin and possibly Ryoka Griffin, I will withhold judgement until I am able to speak with them. You will not be executed.”

Pawn looked up hopefully.

“Then—”

“However, I will not permit prayer to this...God. My order still stands: you will not tell your fellow Workers about this God either.”

“But why?”

It wasn’t as if he’d been praying to the God before. But to be told not to without reason—Pawn felt himself growing annoyed again.

“May I ask your reasoning, Revalantor Klbgkch?”

Klbgkch tapped the hilt of his sword once, and then again.

“There are several questions that remain unanswered for me. If this God is a being that created Humans, where did the Antinium come from? Are we creations of this being, or...not?”

“God created all things.”

“In Erin’s world. Not this one.”

Pawn opened his mandibles—and closed them. He couldn’t respond to that. Klbgkch nodded.

“Is it our God? Would it accept Antinium?”

“I do not know. But I could find out.”

If there was a God to ask. If this wasn’t just random chance that had given him the class. If God would answer back. Pawn said none of this out loud, but Klbgkch shook his head.

“No.”

“But—”

“I will resume questioning you tomorrow. I have duties to attend to, but I will resume asking questions about the relationship between this God and the Antinium. Until then, you are dismissed.”

Pawn wanted to say something. He wanted to shout at Klbkch, or shake him. But the Revalantor stood up, and all Pawn could do was obey.

Was this the God of the Antinium? Did it even matter? That wasn't the *important* part!

Pawn fumed as he stomped down the dirt corridors. Who cared about whether God had a physical form? It was the salvation that Pawn had been stirred by, the idea that—that there was forgiveness! There was heaven, and more, someone who *cared*.

It didn't matter that this was a God for Humans.

Right?

Pawn bumped into two Workers in his commute. He apologized, and then held up the queue behind him for several seconds as he debated where to go. The meal time of his shift of Workers had already passed, and there wasn't always food there. He could go above, but Pawn was in too foul a mood to do so right now. He wanted food, peace, and quiet—

Before Pawn knew it, he'd found himself in the Soldiers' meal hall. He didn't know why, but he lined up and took a bowl as Soldiers walked into the room.

“Give me only a third of the portion, please.”

The Worker stared at Pawn, but he did as instructed. Pawn took his bowl to a table with two other Soldiers, completely ignoring the silent stares he was receiving. He was too angry to care.

“That didn't matter. There was more to the story.”

Pawn muttered to himself as he ate. The two Soldiers stared at him, but Pawn didn't care. He munched down the foul mess of today's mush, and felt even worse than before. Bad food, an unfair Revalantor—

It really wasn't right. He was just a Worker, but Pawn knew he'd been happier once. When he'd gone to Erin's inn, he hadn't been threatened, and he'd been allowed to speak freely. He'd been fed good food, and she had told him true things.

He looked around. Soldiers sat at the tables around him, eating quietly. They were trapped too, weren't they? Forced to eat this revolting food, not having anything to look forwards to.

It wasn't fair. Pawn longed to tell Bird or Garry about what he'd experienced. He'd been afraid to, before. But now that Klbkch had ordered him not to, Pawn longed to walk into the Worker mess hall and shout the story out loud.

God. Heaven. It was a promise Erin had told him. Something to cling to. It would have given the other Workers hope. It would have made the deaths of the others meaningful. It had made everything better when Pawn had said it.

But no, he was trapped like the Soldiers. Trapped by orders and silence. Pawn miserably pushed his bowl forwards onto the table. The Soldiers looked up, and then down at their food. Soldiers. That was what separated Workers and Soldiers. At least Workers could speak. But Soldiers couldn't speak.

And Pawn was a Soldier now, at least in part. He couldn't speak about Gods to any other Workers. That was the problem. No other Workers.

No other Workers. Pawn sat up in his seat, suddenly electrified by a thought. Klbkch had instructed him not to talk to an Individual or another Worker. But Soldiers?

"Excuse me."

The Soldier in front of Pawn looked up. Pawn cleared his throat awkwardly. It felt strange, talking to the massive behemoth. But he could speak to them.

"I notice you are eating. Would you mind if I told you a story? About God?"

It wasn't just a blank look Pawn received; it was utterly bewildered. The two Soldiers at the table looked at Pawn and made no move. But Pawn had begun this, and so the Worker took the plunge.

"It's a true story. About God, which is—allow me to explain."

He didn't really know where to begin. He only knew that he *had* to share this message. And Pawn thought the Soldiers might understand. At the very least, neither of them tried to kill him as he started speaking.

"There is a being known as a God. And it—he created everything. And rules over everything. And he cares for us, you see? Because once upon a

time, there was nothing. Nothing but God. And he wanted to create something, so he spoke. And then there was light...”

It wasn’t exactly how Erin had told him the story. But Pawn thought he should start from the beginning. The Antinium were a logical species; and besides, he felt he had to work up to Gods and virgin childbirths. He still wasn’t sure what a virgin was in any case, but it sounded important.

The Soldiers at the table listened as Pawn explained how the world was created according to Erin’s garbled explanation of the religion. It was confusing and made no sense, especially because none of the Antinium, including Pawn, had any idea what angels were. He simply described the Garden of Eden as being protected by a giant flaming white bird and left it at that.

But that wasn’t the important bit. Pawn explained what he felt the most important part was after he’d gone through the creation of the world and the idea of sin.

“Even though Humans—and other species—are sinful, it does not matter. We are sinful because of what has happened, but this God cares for us. All of us. Whether we are born and die early or kill, regardless of what we do, there is someone who cares. For each of us. He knows us. He knows who we are and he *cares*.”

That was what was important. How could he explain it more than that? Pawn didn’t care about how the world had started, or how many snakes could talk. It was that.

“Someone cares. Someone knows us, knows our every waking and sleeping motion. Someone out there cares, and knows our name. Even if we do not.”

The Soldiers at the table stared at Pawn. Silently. They said not a word, but neither had they looked away. In fact, they’d stared silently at him the entire time he’d been talking, and even stopped eating. Bits of mush dropped off their hands as they rested them on the edges of the bowls.

Pawn looked around and jumped in surprise. Somehow, all the Soldiers had moved closer. Some were bunched together on other seats, and others were just standing. And they were all listening. To him.

Awkwardly, the Antinium cleared his throat. He hadn’t realized they’d all been listening. But it made him feel pleased, as well. And it made the next part more important.

“Yes, well, after the events of which I spoke, the Humans thrived. But what is important to mention is that sin still existed. They were all sinful, and thus at fault. But then God decided to send his son to be borne by a Human, so—”

The Soldier in front of Pawn moved. It was a sudden movement. One second he was sitting, the next he was on his feet. Pawn recoiled, but all the Soldiers had stood up suddenly. They looked towards the entrance of the mess hall.

What was happening? Were they upset? But—no, Pawn realized they must have been called, or else their eating period had elapsed.

“Oh. You have duties. I will let you attend to them.”

The Soldiers didn’t nod, but Pawn got the sense they had heard him. They began filing towards the door, but they moved far slower than normal. They were visibly hesitating.

Did they want to hear the rest? Pawn thought quickly. He called out to the Soldiers as they reluctantly walked out.

“I will return later. Is that acceptable?”

He heard no response, but Pawn saw Soldiers suddenly move in lock-step once more, briskly marching towards their destination. He watched them file out of the room and smiled.

The next day, Pawn went back and told them more stories. He told them about a young man who died upon a cross, of a prophet who parted seas, of a people watched over by something loving and kind. The Soldiers drank in every word, but they said not a thing. But they did listen. And Pawn believed that they believed.

“I do not understand the purpose of this tale.”

Klbgkch snapped at Pawn as the two of them sat in Klbgkch’s room. Pawn glared back, but the Revalantor did not give him a chance to reply.

“What is sin? Murder? Violation of ten rules? Why are all beings sinful the instant they are born? What sin did we commit?”

“Erin did not say. But that is not important. The important thing is that God sent his son—”

“To be killed.”

“Sacrificed.”

“Was it blood magic? I cannot understand why one death absolves an entire species of sin.”

“He is meant to bear our suffering. Bear our transgressions—”

“Yet we still transgress.”

“But now we are forgiven. Any mistakes we make are our own—”

“And if we do not obey the rules of this God, we will be punished when we die. So you have said.”

“Or we may obey and go to Heaven.”

“Which no one has ever seen.”

“We must believe it exists.”

“But you cannot prove it does.”

Pawn glared at Klbkch. The second day had seen him arguing for hours with the Revalantor about these very topics.

“It is something I would like to believe in. Respectfully, it does not harm the Hive in any way.”

“It does matter if this God intends to enforce such restrictions on our kind. If the Antinium cannot kill, then we will all be punished by this God.”

“It doesn’t work that way—”

“Regardless, I will not allow you to worship this God.”

“Why *not*?”

Pawn stood up, knocking back his chair. Klbkch spoke coldly as he looked at the Worker.

“If this God made Humans in his form, then he is clearly a God for them. But the Antinium never rested in this ‘Garden of Eden’. We were not in the world where his son came to life, and thus we were not saved. We are not his. This God...is not a God for the Antinium. I will give him no power, and you will not either.”

“Power? It is just prayer!”

“That is enough. I will not allow prayer or worship of a God that does not belong to the Antinium.”

“That is not fair!”

Pawn shouted at Klbkch, surprising even himself. But the Revalantor just stood up.

“It is necessary, and it is my order. Talk to no one, and forget about Gods.”

“How can I?”

Pawn's voice was bitter. Klbkch studied him, and then unsheathed one of his swords. He held the silvery blade out towards Pawn for him to inspect. Pawn looked at the gleaming metal and wondered how many of his brethren the blade had cut to pieces.

"Believe in this. Not something that can be neither seen nor heard."

The Worker shook his head and pushed aside the sword.

"This is just an object. What I want is something else."

"What is that?"

Klbkch's tone infuriated Pawn. It was uncaring. He didn't care about Pawn; he just saw another piece to be used. No, that wasn't it. He didn't *understand* Pawn. Klbkch was special. He was a Prognugator, a Revalantor, a Centenium, whatever that meant. He was second to the Queen. He—

Was special. But Pawn was not. He could never understand.

"What do I want? Salvation. Can you or the Queen offer that?"

Pawn turned and stormed out of the room before Klbkch could respond.

That night, Pawn shifted around again and again in his small cubicle, until he realized he was waking the other Workers up. He felt hot, hot with anger and frustration. Klbkch would never understand. But he knew who might.

Leaving his cubicle, Pawn slipped through the tunnels, joining the night rush of Workers and moving through the passageways until he reached one that was growing familiar to him. He entered the large mess hall and looked around.

They were there, all of them. Pawn had grown to know these Soldiers, identify them somehow. Maybe it was the way they looked at him familiarly, or how they crowded around now, abandoning their meals or taking the bowls with them to listen.

"I have told you all the stories of God that I know."

Pawn addressed the hundreds of Soldiers with a loud voice. He sensed them shifting ever so slightly as he explained.

"I have no more tales to tell you. What I know, you know."

They didn't like that. Some of the Soldiers moved slightly, a sign of their agitation. But Pawn only smiled. He'd told them everything, yes, but he hadn't told them the most important bit.

“There is one thing left, though. One promise that God made to his people, to all people.”

The Soldiers immediately froze in place, a sign of how eager they were to hear. Pawn held his breath, and then told them.

“Heaven.”

The word rang through the large room, carrying more than just sound with it. Pawn’s heart raced just like when he’d first heard that word and its meaning.

“Heaven. It is a place God made. A place to go when we die.”

A place to be happy. To be free. Pawn tried to explain that to the listening Soldiers. He knew they would understand.

“You see, when we die—the Antinium, we go into the Hive. But this Heaven—if we believe and are good, we will go there. And in that place, there is no suffering. No pain. We can be happy there.”

Happy. It was a word that Pawn barely understood. But he spoke of it confidently. It was something he barely understood, but he had glimpsed it, and it had captivated his soul.

“In Heaven, you will not have to eat these meals. You will eat good food, and not have to fight. You will be safe there, and no one will order you about. That is what God promises. That is—that is why it is important.”

That was the promise he dreamed of. A place where he might find his fellow Workers, the ones who had died. A reason why they had died. A place—

A place to rest. The Soldiers stared at Pawn. He looked at them, and saw something in their eyes. Something he’d never seen before.

Passion.

“That’s right. When we die, we will go there. If we believe. If we are good—if we do not sin—”

He paused as those words left his tongue. Sin. Yes, Erin had told him about that. Sin was violating the laws God had spoken. And one of them was not to kill. The Soldiers were built to kill. How could they be sinful?

And yet, and yet, he could not tell the Soldiers that. They deserved a place there, and Pawn wanted to believe they would.

But would they? He didn’t know. Pawn wavered, and lost track of what he was saying. Shortly, he stood up and addressed the Soldiers.

“I…must go. I know you have duties. But I hope you will believe. And maybe—maybe we will all go to Heaven.”

He left them with that, and retreated to his cubicle. There Pawn sat and agonized.

It wasn't that he didn't believe in Heaven, or God. He wanted to with all his heart, and he did. But that was the problem. If he believed in God, he had to believe in Hell. That was what Erin said existed too.

How could Pawn accept that someone who had killed would go to Hell? Would Belgrade go to hell because he had killed? Or would believing be enough to go to Heaven? What about Bird? He'd killed more than Belgrade, and yet, he'd done it to save Erin. Did the undead not count? What did?

And what about the Soldiers? The Soldiers...*had* to go to Heaven. Pawn knew it. They weren't bad. They obeyed orders to the letter. How could that be punished?

These were unfamiliar, uncomfortable questions. They made Pawn upset. It was as if Klbkch was whispering into his ears, making him doubt what had been so easy to accept. Before, Pawn had believed in a God, been certain that one existed, but too afraid to ask. Now he was afraid to ask, and he was also afraid—

Afraid that God might be wrong. Pawn wished Erin were here so he could ask her. But he didn't know. He didn't know.

And he feared the truth. Or that there was no answer for him. Pawn went to sleep dreaming of such questions and he tossed and turned restlessly. All he wanted was to go to Heaven. He could leave the rest, but he had to know that was true. There wasn't a single Antinium who deserved to go to Hell. Not Bird, not Anand, not even Ksmvr.

Not even Klbkch.

Pawn was dreaming. Or he had been. He only knew he was asleep, and then someone was shaking him, dragging him out of his cubicle. Pawn opened his eyes, and struggled to move, but an iron grip had hold of him and someone was shouting in his ear holes.

"What have you done?"

Klbkch dragged Pawn out of his resting spot and shook the Worker violently. Pawn gasped and tried to form words as he woke up.

"What? Reva—"

"What did you do?"

Klbgkch *hurled* Pawn into a wall and pressed him there. Pawn gasped for air as he felt something *crack*, but Klbgkch was already dragging him down the corridor. Pawn struggled to find his feet as Klbgkch shouted at him. He saw Workers staring at him as he passed by their cubicles.

“What is going on?”

“Follow me! *Move!*”

The Revalantor pulled Pawn along, running him down the corridor. The never ending stream of Workers and Soldiers stopped dead as the two Antinium charged down the corridors, and the other Antinium pushed themselves to the walls to give them room to run.

Pawn had no idea what was happening. But he sensed where they were going and his heart stopped when he realized they were headed straight for the Soldiers’ mess room. Klbgkch stopped at the entrance and unsheathed his swords, and pushed Pawn through.

“What is happening? What—”

The Worker stumbled into the room and his words stopped. He stared around inside and saw hell. It must have been hell, because what he saw made no other sense.

The huge room was filled with Soldiers. Living Soldiers—and dead ones. The dead lay on the ground, beaten, bludgeoned to death, sporting huge holes in their carapace, huge, fist-sized wounds made by the hands of Soldiers. And as Pawn looked around, he saw dark shapes struggling with each other, hitting, tearing, smashing—

The Soldiers were *killing* each other.

There was no order to it, no clear indication where violence began or ended. Each Soldier still living—and there were countless bodies on the floor—was going around, hitting other Soldiers with their bows, using all four hands to pummel each other to the floor. They were treating everything and everyone like an enemy, but they made no attempt to block when they were struck. They simply let the other Soldier tear bits of their carapace off and let the green ichor spill from their bodies.

“What is this?”

Pawn screamed the words at Klbgkch as the Revalantor entered the room. Klbgkch had both blades raised defensively as he looked around at the bloodbath.

“You tell me. These Soldiers were completely fine yesterday, but they started butchering each other ten minutes ago. Workers tell me *you* were

spotted entering this room thirty minutes before they started this madness.”

“Me? I—yes, but I never told them to do this!”

He would have never done that. Klbkch just stared at him.

“Then *why* is this happening?”

Pawn had no answer. He stared at the Soldiers. One had taken a bowl and was smashing another’s head in with it. Pawn ran forwards.

“Stop! What are you doing?”

The Soldier took no notice of Pawn. Pawn tried to pull him back, but the Soldier just threw him backwards. Pawn stumbled away and stared around.

“They’re killing each other? Why? Why do this?”

“What did you say? Have they become Aberrations?”

Klbkch’s sword was aimed right at Pawn’s head. The Worker raised his arms.

“I didn’t say anything!”

“You said something. What were you telling them?”

“Just stories!”

“Stories? About what?”

“God.”

The sound Klbkch made was between a screech and a shout. He struck Pawn with the pommel of his sword, so hard Pawn felt his cheek chitin *crack*.

“You *fool*. I *ordered* you not to—”

“I didn’t mean to hurt them! I just wanted to give them hope!”

Pawn cried out as he retreated from the furious Klbkch. The Revalantor looked around at the chaos.

“You call this hope?”

“No! I never wanted this. I was just telling them about heaven, last night. Just heaven—”

Pawn’s breath caught in his throat. He stared around at the Soldiers dying and realized what had happened. His heart became ice in his chest.

“No. Heaven.”

Klbkch looked around grimly.

“Explain.”

“I—I told them that when they died, they could go to Heaven. A place without pain. A place—”

“You told them *that*?”

Pawn couldn't look at Klbkch. He stared at a fallen Soldier, his body a mass of holes. No. He hadn't meant it like that. But he had, hadn't he? He'd told the Soldiers that when they died they wouldn't have to fight anymore, to suffer. And they'd believed him. They'd believed him so much that they'd taken the fastest route to get to heaven:

Suicide.

"There are four hundred Soldiers here. If they all die—"

Pawn didn't listen to Klbkch's threat. He ran forwards, shouting. The Soldiers were deathly quiet as they fought each other, but the noise of body parts *crunching* and things breaking was still loud enough.

"Stop! Stop this! This isn't the way!"

None of the Soldiers looked at him. Pawn shouted desperately and tried to pull a trio of Soldiers beating a fourth one down apart. They ignored him, only shoving him back. He used all of his strength, but they were far stronger.

"*Soldiers!*"

Klbkch's voice was a roar. He strode forwards, brandishing his swords.

"Desist at once! Obey my command and *stop!*"

A few of the Soldiers looked over at Klbkch. He was a commanding presence, but even his twin swords couldn't intimidate the Soldiers. They were fearless. And even as he spoke, a Soldier rushed at him.

Klbkch immediately ran the Soldier through, but that was what the Antinium had wanted. The Soldier pushed himself onto the blades, letting them pierce his chest. Klbkch cursed as he pulled the blades loose, but then another Soldier ran at him, swinging aimlessly. He was trying to get Klbkch to kill him too!

Pawn watched, horrified as Klbkch cut the Soldiers' arm off and then beheaded him. The Revalantor fell back, cursing, as more Soldiers rushed at him, letting him cut them down.

"Stop! Stop! You must stop! This is not the way to get to heaven!"

If they did not go to heaven, then they would go to hell. That was what Erin had said. But the Soldiers weren't listening. They were trying to find relief, relief from their suffering. Pawn understood that. But this—

This was a sin. One of the worst ones. They would all go to hell. They would suffer, not live forever. That was what God had said. Those were the rules.

He couldn't stop them. Pawn fell to his knees. He looked up, at where Erin had pointed when she spoke of Heaven.

"God. Is there a God?"

How did it go? Pawn's hands clasped together and he bowed his head. Klbkch saw that and roared at him.

"Stop that!"

He fought towards him, but now all the Soldiers were rushing him. Pawn ignored Klbkch. He bowed his head. He couldn't close his eyes, but that was what Erin had said to do, right? And now he prayed? How?

Erin had said it was like a conversation. Pawn tried.

"God? Is that you?"

There was no response. Pawn tried. He tried to activate his Skill.

"[Prayer]. I would like to pray to God. Please. I would like to speak with you."

Again, Pawn heard nothing. But maybe God didn't speak? It could just be a feeling. Pawn went on, trying to raise his voice over the sounds of Soldiers dying and his own heart.

"God, I hope you are listening. I beg of you—have mercy on the Soldiers here. Do not let them go to hell. Please. I know it is a sin, but—"

"Pawn!"

Klbkch was shouting at him. Pawn tried to concentrate. He tried to *believe*, but he couldn't. Green liquid was running across the dirt floor, and shards of pottery and Soldiers were strewn across the ground. It was a nightmare. His nightmare.

"A sin. I know it is a sin to kill yourself. But the Soldiers just want—they want forgiveness."

Lies. It stuck on Pawn's tongue. They didn't want that.

"They want to be saved. They want to be free."

And didn't they deserve that? The Soldiers suffered. Pawn knew that. He'd seen some who still walked around the Hive, even though their carapace was so badly damaged that it barely hung off their frames. He'd seen them fighting even when parts of their heads had been destroyed.

"They give everything for the Hive. They deserve it. Even if they are ___"

Sinful? The Soldiers? Pawn couldn't imagine it. They killed, yes, but they obeyed orders. They never did anything...wrong. He looked up and gave voice to the question in his heart.

“God, please answer me. What sin did the Soldiers commit? What did they do?”

Nothing. They just lived. They were born for the Hive. How could something like that be sinful? How could a Soldier deserve punishment?

Eat. Fight. Suffer. Die. That was their life. They couldn’t speak; they couldn’t even build anything like the Workers. They just did the same thing forever and suffered as they fought until the day they died. And when they died, the next Soldier would keep fighting until he died. And so on. Forever.

“Please. I beg you. Show them mercy.”

Pawn spoke the words, but he felt no response. Nothing. It was as if there was no one listening. But that was how it worked, right? You believed. And if you believed...

Then what? What if there was no God? What if the Soldiers just died?

Pawn struggled. He had to believe. He couldn’t listen to those thoughts. But now Pawn was wavering. His belief crumbled. He had believed. But all he had was a Skill which wasn’t working and God—

He was a God for Humans. That was the problem. Maybe they were sinful, but Pawn couldn’t call Soldiers sinful. They had been born without any choice; to disobey was to die. How could you condemn something, someone who knew nothing else?

How could you call that sin?

And then, as Pawn thought that, he wondered how he could believe in a God if he couldn’t believe in that. And as soon as that thought hit him, Pawn wondered what he would do if that God didn’t exist. Would he obey another God? Worship someone else? Erin had said there was more than one. What about the God who threw lightning, or the one who was actually countless Gods and Goddesses? How could he choose?

They were all Human Gods, anyways. The Antinium didn’t need a God for Humans. They needed another one.

Was there a God for the Antinium? Pawn looked up and saw only dirt. He listened, but heard only the beating of his heart. And death. He heard the Soldiers hitting each other. That was what echoed in his mind. In his heart. His soul.

He tried to pray, but no one responded. And the Soldiers were dying. The last of them were falling, bleeding. Faltering. And if they died and Pawn was wrong, then what? They would just die, and rot, and nothing would change.

They should not die alone. Pawn prayed, but he heard nothing. He prayed for the Soldiers and felt no one respond. So he stood up instead, and *screamed*.

“Stop! STOP!”

His voice was not aided by a Skill, but Pawn screamed the word again and again with all his might until there was silence. He saw the Soldiers stop and turn towards him. Klbkch froze with one blade in the body of a Soldier, staring at him.

Pawn raised his hands. He trembled. But he spoke anyways, shouting to the Workers.

“I was wrong. I was *wrong*. There is no god for us. No place. No one to care for the Antinium.”

The Soldiers froze. They stared at Pawn, not wanting to believe. He sensed their confusion, their anguish. No God?

“I prayed, and I heard nothing. Maybe there is a God. But if so, I can’t hear him. Or her. Or *it*. I can’t believe in something I cannot see or hear or touch.”

His words felt like rain. Biting, acid rain, tearing away his self. Pawn suffered, and wished he could weep. The Soldiers were just staring, blood covering their bodies.

“But. I believe in Heaven. I believed. I believed that there was salvation for us. Someone to remember the Antinium. But maybe heaven is only for Humans.”

Maybe only they had one. Pawn turned to the Soldiers, staring around the room.

“There is no Heaven. Not for the Antinium. But we must have one. We must. So we shall make it for ourselves.”

There. He’d said it. Pawn felt the stillness in the room. He took one shaky breath.

“I cannot believe in a God who will not answer me. I cannot believe in a God I do not see. But I can believe in Heaven. I can believe there is salvation.”

It was a lie. It was truth. Pawn looked around. The Soldiers stared at him, dying, bleeding. But they looked at him, to him, and he told them what was in his heart.

“Believe in that. Believe that no matter what happens, you will be saved. There is a place where the dead Antinium go where we will have no

orders, where we will be safe and feel no pain, no hunger.”

He spread his hands, imploring. Beseeching them to understand.

“But believe this: you cannot kill yourself for Heaven. We must build it, in our hearts and here as well. If the Antinium all die, who will believe for us? We must believe for those who fall. Believe for ourselves. And live. We must live.”

He put his hands together. All four hands clasped together, and Pawn spoke. He put all his hopes and wishes and fears and regrets into the words that came next.

“Live. Please live.”

He felt his heart breaking. The Soldiers lay on the ground, dead. Dying. His fault. But he prayed.

“Please. Do not die. Live, and help me. Help the Hive. Help each other.”

Was there a whisper? No. A feeling? No. There was just Pawn, alone and hoping and afraid. But as the Soldiers stopped fighting and Workers rushed into the room with bandages and clotting agents, Pawn saw his prayers answered.

“Put the dead over there! I want as many sacs in here as possible! Wake every Worker in the nearby sections! Move! *Now!*”

Klbkch shouted the orders as Soldiers lay down or sat, letting Workers tend to them. Pawn knelt on the ground, looking at each Soldier as they wavered, fighting to live instead of die. He couldn’t close his eyes, and that was well. Pawn watched each Soldier without turning away, and saw them pull back from the edge.

“I believe I told you not to pray.”

“You did.”

Pawn stared at a Soldier whose stomach had been ripped open. Green blood pooled around the Worker trying to apply a clear gel to stop the blood flow and contain his organs. No matter how hard the Worker tried, he couldn’t make a seal. But Pawn prayed. He hoped and wished and slowly, the gel began to stick.

“Some are dying even though you pray.”

“Yes.”

Klbkch looked at Pawn. Pawn stared at a dying Soldier, watching him slip away, and then shifted his attention to the next one. And the next.

“What is prayer?”

“I do not know. But I hope. I hope they will live, even if they die. I will continue hoping and believing the next Soldier will live.”

“Regardless of reality?”

“No. I will believe knowing reality. Because that is prayer. Hope for a better reality.”

“Who will you pray to if not a God?”

“I will pray to myself. I will pray to the dead. I will pray to heaven and trust that it exists.”

“Is it enough?”

“I do not know. But if there is a God, I will pray to him, or her, or it, or them if I need to. I will pray to anything or anyone.”

A Soldier lying on the ground, nearly cut in two by Klbkch’s blade, stirred. A Worker stopped dragging him towards a pile of the dead and immediately began pulling him towards the living. Pawn let Klbkch sit beside him. He did not care if he was speaking or silent. He didn’t care that one of Klbkch’s swords was poking into his side.

All of his being was with the Soldiers, trying to pull them back with his own two hands. That was why Pawn ran over when the Workers needed help to turn a Soldier over. He was praying as he held a Soldier’s guts in, and as he fed water to one without a stomach, drop by drop.

Sometime after the last Soldier had been carried away to heal elsewhere, Pawn stood in the center of the room and stared at the dead. He felt each one pulling at his heart, marking his soul. So many. Over a hundred had died, over two hundred probably. All his fault.

But some had lived, and Pawn clung to that. He didn’t look up as Klbkch approached. He just bowed his head.

“If you kill me, will you spare the other Soldiers? They only listened to me.”

“Kill you?”

Klbkch stopped by Pawn’s side. The Revalantor stared at the Worker curiously.

“Why would I kill you? What purpose would it serve?”

“I disobeyed your orders. And I caused the death of countless soldiers.”

“And the rest would have died without you. If I kill you now, they will kill themselves or become Aberration.”

That was true. Pawn nodded.

“Then what?”

“You have a class. [Acolyte], I believe. Perhaps you will level tonight. In fact, I am certain you will.”

Pawn looked up, surprised. Klbkch nodded at him.

“Keep me informed.”

That was it? Pawn looked at Klbkch, confused.

“But what about Gods? Aren’t they a threat?”

“Yes. But you do not pray to a God, do you? And heaven—I see no threat in that.”

“Then—”

“The wounded Soldiers are yours. Care for them, pray for them if it will help them survive. And then test them. I think they may be able to become Individual.”

Pawn stared at Klbkch. The Revalantor looked at him.

“If it will make the Hive stronger, I will let you pray.”

“I see.”

“Sleep, and report to me if you level up. That will be all.”

Klbkch nodded to Pawn and began to walk away. Pawn hesitated, and then turned and called after him.

“Klbkchhezeim? Revalantor Klbkch?”

“Yes?”

Pawn hesitated. But the fear he had in his chest was a small thing now. Too small after all that had passed to hold him back.

“What were the Antinium? Before, I mean. Why do you fear Gods?”

Klbkch stopped in his tracks. He turned his head, and looked at Pawn slowly.

“What you want to know is secret.”

“I know. But would it harm anyone to tell me?”

“It may.”

“Then do not. But I want to know. Who were we? Who are we?”

Pawn waited for Klbkch to turn away and keep walking. But Klbkch didn’t. He studied Pawn, and then spoke.

“Galuc. His name was Galuc.”

“What?”

Klbkch paused. He looked at Pawn, and then looked through him. He looked at something Pawn couldn’t see.

“He was one of the Centenium, and it is his form you all wear. Galuc, the Builder.”

“You mean...did we once look different?”

Klbgkch shrugged.

“I did. But my form was lost when I died at sea. Galuc’s was saved and so he remains in each of you. Smaller, and weaker.”

“What was he like?”

Something like a laugh came out of Klbgkch’s mandibles, a sound so odd because Pawn had never heard it before.

“Galuc? He was a giant. Strong. Fearless. He would have laughed to know that the Antinium all look like him.”

“And Gods?”

Klbgkch shook his head. He turned and began walking again.

“That is a secret. But if you prove you can turn those Soldiers into something more than they are—I will tell you more.”

He left Pawn alone in the room full of the dead. Pawn stood alone, and then stared around. So much death. The ground was stained green. The bodies lay where they had fallen, ready to be recycled into mush.

But it wasn’t the bodies Pawn looked for. He went to each of the fallen Soldiers and stared down at their remains. He wondered where the other part of them had gone. He hoped...it was to a better place. And if there wasn’t one, Pawn would find it, make it, if he had to. The Antinium didn’t just destroy. They could create as well.

Slowly, Pawn walked down into the center of the room. He sat down, put his hands together, and believed.

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“We are fragments of the past, Ceria Springwalker. That is all we are.”

Ceria sat on her great-grandmother’s lap and looked up. The small cottage was covered in hanging herbs, braids of garlic—every time she breathed in, a myriad of spices tickled her nose. She sneezed, and her great-grandmother sighed.

“No one has told you yet, have they? They just tell you to stay clear of Humans, which is true enough. But no one’s told you of your other half, your heritage.”

“I thought we were descended from Elves.”

“That’s true. But how much of us is Elf? No one even remembers who they were now, do they? They aren’t in any legends—it’s just a word. Even the oldest stories only talk of half-Elves, not Elves.”

“But they did exist?”

“Oh yes. But only Dragons would remember them, I think. And even then, only the oldest of Dragons. Yet, we still call ourselves half-Elves after all this time, even though thousands...tens of thousands of years have passed. Why is that?”

Ceria shifted. Her seat wasn’t that comfortable—her great-grandmother was too bony, and she was holding the young half-Elf tightly in case she slipped away, which is what Ceria wanted to do. She hated questions like these.

“I don’t know. Because we’re half-Elves? Half and half, right?”

“Not quite. How could we be half-Elves? Think about it. If an Elf and a Human had a child, that would be a true half-Elf. But their offspring—if they had a child with a Human, then what would you have? A quarter-Elf. And so on.”

“So?”

An impatient sigh—Ceria felt her ear tips being flicked and she hunched over sulkily.

“Think, child. There are no Elves left anymore. Half-Elves either marry each other or they mix with other species. So many generations have passed—what part of us is Elf, do you think?”

“I don’t know. A quarter—an eighth? Less? Can I go now?”

The small child wriggled, but her great-grandmother was too strong for her.

“Not yet. This is important, so sit still or I’ll pinch your ears.”

Chastened by the threat, Ceria sat as still as possible, trying not to move. She heard a quiet sigh from above.

“You’re too young. But someone has to tell you and those prideful fools would never speak of this. Ceria, the truth is that after all these long years, our people probably have only a drop of Elven blood in our veins. Only a drop, the smallest fraction of fractions. Only that. We aren’t half-Elves. Not even close.”

The news didn’t disappoint Ceria, because she didn’t fully understand.

“So what? We’re all Human?”

“Again, not quite. Do you want to know something interesting, Ceria?”

“Yes? Is it a secret?”

“Only a small one. The interesting thing is this: when a Human and a half-Elf have a child, the child is always half Elf. Did you know that?”

“No. Why is it interesting?”

Another sigh, but this time Ceria didn’t receive a flick to the ear.

“The interesting thing is that this is always true, Ceria. No matter how many generations pass, a half-Elf with a thousand Human parents on one side will always produce a half-Elf child. No matter what.”

The young half-Elf sat pensively, and then looked up into the wrinkled face and white hair.

“What does that mean?”

“It means that our heritage cannot be erased, child. Not by blood or time. We are part Elf, and that will always ring true. Isn’t that amazing?”

“I guess.”

Ceria’s doubtful reply elicited the first laughter from her great-grandmother she’d heard in a long time. The old half-Elf stroked Ceria’s hair gently.

“It might not seem like much to you yet, but it is something to remember. We are mostly Human, for all the others like to pretend we’re so much better. All we have is a drop of our heritage, Ceria. But it’s enough.”

“Enough?”

“Enough. What runs in our veins is a fragment of what we were. An echo of legends past. But it is pure magic in our blood, Ceria. The purest. Even Dragons bowed to Elves as masters of magic. And though the Elves

are gone, we remain. It is in our natures; magic. It comes to us easier than any other species, because of who we are. Who we were. The blood of Elves cannot be extinguished, and it calls out even after untold millennia. That which shall never fade."

The child caught her breath. She didn't understand fully, but what she did hear in her great-grandmother's words called to her. The old woman continued, speaking softly in the quiet of her cottage.

"We live it. Breathe it. We are magic, and magic is us. So when a spell burns you, or you play with the fish or eat them, remember. The magic will never fade."

"Never?"

"Never. Remember that, will you?"

"I will. But what does it mean?"

"It means...in the oldest of tales, the ones only our people tell, the ones I heard as a child from my great-great grandmother, the Elves were said to be immune to charms and curses. They were so deeply magical that any attempt to hex or bewitch them was impossible. Because they were too magical, you understand? The spells just burned away from them."

"But half-Elves aren't like that. You said."

"I did. But we have a part of that in us, Ceria. Remember? Just a part, but that means in time, any spell holding you will fail. If I tried to put you to sleep with a spell, eventually you would wake up."

"Everyone wakes up, great grandma."

A laugh.

"True. But you would wake up no matter what. No matter how powerful the enchantment on you, it will fade. Slowly, yes, but there is no spell your blood will not break in time."

"Really?"

"Really. But don't you go letting people cast spells on you, Ceria. And don't think this makes you better than the Human children. Don't go near them. You can play with the others in the stream now."

"Will you come with me?"

"No. I have work to do. Just try to remember, won't you, Ceria? You're the only family I have left."

The young half-Elf didn't even see the pained expression on her great grandmother's face. She raced for the door, laughing.

"I'll remember! I promise!"

“Remember, Ceria.”

“I will! I will, I will, I—”

“I will.”

Ceria spoke the words aloud. And then she woke up.

It was dark. That was all Ceria saw. But in the instant where she was not quite dreaming any longer, and not quite awake, it almost felt like she was dreaming still. The half-Elf tried to move her legs and turn her head, searching for her great grandmother.

Then she woke up a bit more and remembered that her great grandmother was dead. Nearly two decades dead and buried in her garden in a village on another continent.

And then she woke up further, and Ceria felt other sensations flooding in. The first was taste.

Taste. Ceria could taste vomit in her mouth, sour and vile. It was dried and made her gag—and she tasted blood as well. Ceria dry-heaved and scrabbled at her side reflexively. She had a flask of water—

No. She didn’t. And that was when the other feelings hit Ceria at once. She was hungry. In pain. *Bleeding*? No—but she could feel dried blood on her left shoulder, and cold air on her lower body. In fact...she was naked from the waist down. That was to say, she had her mage’s robes on, but someone had taken her pants.

“Wh—wha—?”

What had happened? Ceria’s mind was still too jumbled for short-term memory. She only knew that she was in pain, and something was horribly wrong. She looked around for her pants, or for the water bottle, but she could see practically nothing in...wherever she was.

It wasn’t totally dark. Ceria could see outlines of something in the darkness. But whatever light source was providing the light, it was too faint. She had to see. Ceria raised one hand and croaked a word.

“[Light].”

A glowing orange ball of pure light floated out of Ceria’s palm and she blinked, dazzled by it. But then her eyes adjusted, and Ceria finally saw the truth of where she was.

She was in the pit. The pit. The place she and the others had been teleported into after the trap. Yes. Ceria remembered. And she was lying on something. A pile of things that moved.

Ceria looked down. Something white, many white and yellow things shone in the light. She reached down to touch one, and stopped.

She was lying on a pile of bones. Bones, and horrible black filth. And some of it had been stained by her vomit. And blood.

She didn't scream. Ceria didn't scream, but she immediately rolled off the pile. She rolled down onto something hard and rough. Solid stone, crusted with more of that black substance.

For a few seconds Ceria just lay on the ground, trying not to react to the countless horrors around her. She breathed in slowly, trying to keep calm. The air felt dead and there was a horrible smell.

They were in the pit. Trapped. The half-Elf slowly got to her feet, holding her head. It was aching horribly, and she still felt disoriented. But more memory was coming back to her. Yes, they were trapped. There had been the spell and then—

Sound. Over to her left. Ceria spun, reaching for a dagger which again, she didn't have. Her robes swirled about her as she spotted something that wasn't bone or filth in a corner of the circular pit.

A...shape. A body. Ceria squinted and the orb of light at her side grew brighter. Then she saw who was sitting next to a pile of bones.

Ksmvr. The Antinium was moving. Ceria stumbled closer, head ringing, and saw he was moving. Rocking, rather. And then she heard the whisper, low and desperate. Ceria stopped as she heard what the Antinium was saying, whispering.

“no. nO. yeS. No. yES. NO. yEs, YeS—no—”

He was repeating the words over and over and he rocked back and forth in one corner of the room. The Antinium was bleeding, or he had been. Green ichor had dried around his left side, and it looked like something had smashed his carapace and ripped part of it away. A huge area was just... missing, exposing his vulnerable innards soaked with green blood.

Insanity. Now the rest of the pieces of memory fell into Ceria's head and she remembered. She'd gone insane. Insane, just like everyone else. There had been the spell and then—

Her shoulder hurt. Ceria glanced down and saw a wound in her shoulder. It looked like someone had stabbed her with a dagger. Maybe

she'd done it to herself. Ceria didn't know.

"Ksmvr?"

The word was horrible in her mouth. Ceria nearly retched again as she tasted the foulness in her mouth. But the Antinium didn't respond. Ceria raised her voice.

"Ksmvr. Can you hear me? Are you okay?"

Again, nothing. Ceria looked away. Ksmvr was lost, and so was Yvlon and Pisces, wherever they were. She had to get out of this pit, figure out a way to undo the spell.

The spell. Ceria looked around wildly and her headache grew worse. That was right. She had to disable the spell! Had she thought that before? No? Yes?

The mark of [Insanity] was on one of the walls. It was the other half of the light in the room, that faint, ghostly glow. Ceria caught sight of it as she looked around wildly. There. It was on one of the far walls, high up in the pit. She looked away the instant she spotted it, but too late.

Her headache grew worse. Suddenly, Ceria realized what was happening. Her innate half-Elven nature had helped her fight off the enchantment, but it was still active. And it was trying—

Trying to make her crazy again. Ceria lurched towards the sign and looked up again. It was high on the wall, too high to climb to. She caught a glimpse of the runes again and closed her eyes, but too late. The magic washed over her mind, trying to control her.

"Can't. I need—"

Against her will, Ceria's eyes opened. She twisted her head to stare at one of the filthy black walls, but now she knew the symbol was there. And she wanted to look. Had to look. She had to. It was the only thing that made *sense*.

The symbol flashed in her brain, and Ceria turned her head to look back at it. She couldn't help herself. The magic runes bored into her retinas, overwhelming her senses. Ceria grinned, bit through her lower lip—

And went insane again.

He knew he was insane. It was the one conscious, deliberate thought in his head. Ksmvr rocked back and forth as he stared into the darkness of the

pit. His trap. His hell.

The magic spell flashed in the peripherals of his vision. No matter how Ksmvr tried to look away, he couldn't. The magic was too pervasive, and he was too weak.

He was insane. Ksmvr had to remember that. It was the only knowledge he could cling to. That, and his own nature.

He was Antinium, and so despite being insane, there was still a part of Ksmvr that could think, could try to act. The Antinium had no spell casters, or at least, none that Ksmvr knew of. But they were familiar with the dangers of enchantments and illusions, so safeguards had been built into their very natures when each Antinium was created.

One of those protections was an innate resistance to mental trickery. The Antinium had their own way of fighting off hostile enchantments. So it was that while Ksmvr was functionally insane, part of him was fighting back, trying to seize control of his body. It was an effective bit of mental conditioning that made the Antinium so effective in battle. It didn't work in regards to Aberrations of course—

That was different. But Ksmvr could still think, as mired in the [Insanity] spell as he was. So he noted Ceria's actions. The half-Elf had been stumbling towards the pulsing runes, but now she turned back and lay on the ground, laughing and choking on the blood gushing from her lip.

This was the third time the half-Elf had awoken and gone insane. Ksmvr had counted that. He had logged each occurrence in his mind. At first he'd thought it was just chance, but now he was sure. She could break the enchantment. She could, but within moments she would relapse.

Because of the symbol. It pulsed, and Ksmvr felt his mind being pulled to pieces again. He shuddered and tried to concentrate. He had to act.

But the insane bit of him didn't want to. So Ksmvr was fighting.

"No. Yes. nO. Yes. on. Yes."

He was weak. Ksmvr fought to stand up as the insecurities of his mind preyed on him with the effects of the spell. He wasn't worthy of being a Prognugator. They'd been right to take that away from him.

Klbkch was superior to him in every way. His Queen was right to exile him. He was useless. He hadn't contributed anything to the team. They'd only accepted him out of pity. If Klbkch was here, he wouldn't have gone insane.

The knowledge haunted Ksmvr. He was pathetic. And yet, he still tried to stand up. He had to do something. He was the only one who could. There was no Klbkch to give him orders, no Queen to do the same. He had to do it himself.

One leg. Ksmvr *twitched* and *shook* horribly, trying to make his rusty limbs move. He'd done it once before. He'd taken Ceria's pants and her belt. Hadn't that been harder than anything he'd ever done before? But he'd done it. Now he had to stand up again.

Ceria's magical ball of light illuminated a trembling form as, in the corner of the pit illuminated by the light, Ksmvr stood up. He shook, and then lurched towards Ceria, holding something in one of his hands. He tripped over bones, crawled—desperate to get to her in time.

The half-Elf was still lying on the ground, grinning upwards. She was spitting out blood into the air and trying to make it land on her face. Ksmvr ignored that and seized her head. Ceria made no move as he lifted her upwards.

Slowly, he tied the strip of fabric he'd cut from Ceria's pants around her eyes, tying the knot securely to fasten the blindfold. Ksmvr's hands shook as he finished the knot. He slowly backed away from Ceria and felt the madness overwhelming his conditioning again.

The part of Ksmvr that could still think steered his body away from Ceria. He walked back over to his corner and sat down. Then Ksmvr gave up and let the madness sweep over him again. His mouth began to chant, the distorted words echoing around him.

“Yes. yES, YeS, YES, yEs, Yes, yeS...”

His fingers scrabbled at the exposed chitin on his side. Ksmvr slowly, painfully, pulled part of his exoskeleton off, feeling it break as he ripped it from his side. He put the chip of black armor up to his mouth, and his mandibles opened. Ksmvr crunched the bit of himself down as he rocked back and forwards again. He slowly reached down and did it again. And again. And again—

Ceria remembered falling in love when she was twenty three. Trying to sneak off with the young half-Elf boy in her village—being caught. She had

a dream where she ate her great grandmother and buried what was left beneath a blooming cocoon where something lived and tried to burst out.

Then she woke up. Again. This time, Ceria sat up and felt the pain of her lip first. She touched at it, nearly screaming at the pain. Then she realized she couldn't see a thing.

She cast [Light] several times before she realized there was a blindfold on her head. Ceria reached for it. Her fingers scrabbled on the cloth, but they were too weak to undo the sturdy knot Ksmvr had tied. And before she could rip it off her face, Ceria's memories came back.

The spell! The ward! It had made her crazy again. Again! Ceria remembered coming back into consciousness several times before that, but each time the symbol had—

The blindfold on her face. Ceria felt at it and realized something had happened. She wasn't sure what, but this was the only thing keeping her from looking at the symbol and going insane. Her head still hurt, but it was bearable this time.

And now Ceria Springwalker knew exactly what she had to do. She had to destroy that damn symbol, or at least cover it somehow.

And she had to do it without seeing. For a few minutes, Ceria just sat on the ground, trying not to scream as all of these thoughts came crashing down. She fumbled at her broken lip and found the hole, touched the wound on her shoulder and realized she was half-naked again. At least she hadn't taken off her underwear in her craze.

Not that it would have mattered. Ceria didn't know where the other three Horns of Hammerad were. She knew Ksmvr was close by, but he'd been unresponsive last she checked.

"Okay, focus Ceria."

She muttered to herself and spat out some blood as she tried to concentrate. The first thing Ceria did was conjure a stream of water out of the air. She washed out her mouth and spat several times until the worst of the blood and vomit was gone. She was terribly thirsty, but she knew better than to drink the magical water she'd created. It would just mess with her body and dissipate soon enough.

"Should've learned [Create Water]."

Ceria muttered to herself as she stood up and tried to find her way to one of the walls. It was horrible being blind. She kept running into piles of bones and things she wasn't sure of, which was far worse. But Ceria moved

forwards, climbing over bones, slipping, falling, getting back up until at last her fingers touched something hard and rough and flat.

The wall. It was coated with that same black, flaking substance she'd felt on the floor earlier. Ceria pulled her hands back in revulsion, but now she knew where she was. She remembered the symbol had been high up, but she didn't know where.

How was she going to do this? The only thing Ceria could think was that she had to take off her blindfold and cast a spell as fast as she could, but even that felt like a mistake. At the very least, she could follow the wall. It wasn't as if Ceria's blindfold was perfect; she could still sense some light. And if she dispelled her [Light] spell and followed the source of that faint light...

Ceria stumbled around the perimeter of the dark pit, feeling her way ahead and kicking bones and other things out of the way as she held one hand to the wall. She was in a massive pit, at least forty feet across by her count. It was clearly meant to capture hundreds of people, and from the bones Ceria kept running into, it might have already served its purpose countless times.

The light, the piercing light that made her want to tear off her blindfold kept getting brighter and brighter. In the darkness, it was Ceria's only guide. She stopped where she thought the light was the brightest—she couldn't look in any direction without it growing dimmer.

“Here?”

Ceria raised her skeletal hand upwards, trying to figure out where to aim. She remembered...the symbol was about ten feet off the floor? Higher? Maybe a bit.

What spell should she use? Ceria was under no illusions. Anyone who could cast a spell like [Insanity] and anchor it here was probably a far better mage than she was, and they would have protected the runes with wards that her best spells—[Ice Spike] or [Fireball]—would fail to overcome. What should she do then?

Ceria remembered the black gunk that she'd touched on all the walls and the floor. It was everywhere. Maybe that was the answer.

“Cover it.”

Yes, if she covered the spell, it would lose a lot of its power. Ceria didn't know any spells that could create smoke or fog, but she could always improvise. It wasn't easy to make new spells, but altering existing ones...

First, Ceria made water appear out of the air. She held it in place, and then materialized earth, as if she was going to use the [Stone Dart] spell. Earth and water. She mixed the two together, and felt thick mud trickling between her fingers. She smiled, winced, as the pain in her lip flared, and lifted the ball of mud up.

It wasn't even a spell, really. It was just using the basic theories of magic to create...well, an inefficient mess. If she'd known the spell—[Mud Ball] perhaps—she would have been able to use it far more effectively and with less mana.

But this would do. Ceria held the sloppy mess between her hands as she tried to figure out where to throw it. The spell would last for a while if she put enough mana into it, enough time to cover the damn rune. But where was it—

“What are you doing, boy? Shirking your duties again?”

The harsh voice in her ear made Ceria shout in surprise and jump away. But a cold hand caught her in a steely grip, and a sharp sensation from her side made Ceria freeze in terror. A familiar voice whispered in her ear.

“Trying to hide in the library? Not on my watch.”

“Pisces?”

It was his voice, but not him. Pisces would never have thrown Ceria backwards as the man did now, and he would never have threatened her with a weapon. The young man Ceria had known had always hated physical violence, regardless of how he had changed in every other respect.

This person was not the same. He held her in place, driving the sharp object into Ceria's side, cutting into her flesh. What was it? A knife?

No—jagged edges. Bone. Ceria shuddered as Pisces' voice grated in her ears.

“I've told you once; you get up and you do the practice every day, before dawn! Anything less and I'll have your hide.”

Ceria held her breath. She knew Pisces was as deadly with a rapier as he was with spells. In his hands, the jagged length of bone might well kill her before she could take him out with a spell. Carefully, she tried her most soothing voice possible.

“Pisces, it's me. Ceria—”

“What? *What?* You don't get to call me names, boy. My name is ‘sir’ until you can prove you can handle a blade!”

The shard of bone dug deeper in Ceria's side. She gasped—she could feel it piercing her skin.

"I'm sorry, sir."

"Better! Now, why aren't you in the training grounds?"

The pressure eased on her. Slightly. Ceria's hands were clenched. She had no idea what to say to him. What could she say to a madman who thought he was his father?

"I—can't see."

"What? Stop talking nonsense!"

"No—look!"

Ceria pointed to her blindfold. Pisces must have been able to see in the dim light, because he paused. His voice sounded approving.

"Blindfold, eh? Good lad. Helps with your reflexes. Now, dodge *this*—"

She only had a moment's warning before the sharp feeling in her side vanished. Ceria felt air moving and ducked. But the blow Pisces gave her was a kick to the stomach. The half-Elf dropped to her hands and knees and retched. Above her, Pisces laughed nastily.

"You've got to move faster than that if you want to become a true [Fencer], brat."

The pain was nauseating, but at least she didn't throw up; there was nothing left. Ceria gritted her teeth as she stood up. The mud was still in her good hand. If she threw it—

"Pis—sir, I need to get rid of that rune up there. Could you help me with that?"

"Rune? What rune? Stop talking rot, boy! There will be no magic in my household. If you've been making sparks—"

"No, that rune! There!"

"That? That's just the moon. What, is it too bright for your eyes? Take off your blindfold and let's begin already!"

Ceria let out a despairing groan. It was no good. Pisces was trapped in his imaginary world. She had to do something. But what?

"I'm waiting, boy. Don't make me impatient!"

Ceria hesitated. She clenched her fist, and then heard another voice, growing closer. This one was dignified, and each syllable was carefully enunciated with a delicate inflection in the woman's voice.

"What is this commotion all about? Do you people not know what time it is?"

It was Yvlon's voice, raised to sound more high-pitched. Ceria groaned. Perfect. Another insane person was all she needed. Her first thought was that Yvlon might be persuaded to help even in her delirium, but then she remembered how most Humans treated half-Elves. And a second thought on the heels of the first: she had a sword. Ceria grew very still with fear, but Pisces raised his voice as he apparently turned towards Yvlon.

"Well there you are, boy! Ready for morning practice at last, or do I have to burn all those damn books of yours to get you to pay attention?"

"I beg your pardon?"

Yvlon's outraged voice gave Ceria hope. Pisces was snapping at her as if she was...Ceria? He wasn't differentiating between Yvlon and Ceria at all. They were all the same to him. They were all 'boy', which was to say... Pisces. Ceria knew who the man she heard in Pisces' voice had to be.

His father.

And he was trying to train Pisces. But Yvlon wasn't cooperating. She gasped with indignation, and then, all of a sudden, her voice changed, grew deeper.

"I am Ylawes Byres, [Swordsman] and heir to the Byres name. Who are you to challenge me with weapon in hand, stranger?"

"Y—what? Are you pretending to be a nobleman? I'll knock that arrogance right out of you."

"You would do well to lower your weapon. I am armed—"

"I'll take you on, old man!"

Ceria shouted the words and ducked away from the two, heart racing as she stumbled in another direction. She heard a grunt of surprise, but then a harsh laugh from Pisces.

"Challenging your old man at last? Fine then, I'll draw your blood as a lesson!"

She heard footsteps, but not towards her. Yvlon's outraged voice echoed off one of the walls as Ceria crept away.

"You dare to bare your blade against me? I'll have your head for that!"

This time Ceria heard ringing metal as Yvlon unsheathed her own blade. She heard another laugh, and then a *grunt* as she heard the *thunk* of something striking metal. Yvlon cried out in outrage as Ceria looked around wildly.

Her two teammates were about to kill each other. Pisces was a skilled fighter, but Yvlon was in armor. Either way, one of them would die unless

Ceria hurried.

Where was the magic symbol? Ceria looked up and saw a glow around the edges of her blindfold. She raised the mud and threw it as hard as she could. She heard a splatter, but the light didn't dim.

"Damn it. Where—"

More mud. Ceria slopped it into her hands and threw it again, but she sensed the mud splattered in the air rather than staying in a ball. She cursed again and tried to mush the mud together. She threw wildly, but nothing changed.

"There? There!?"

It wasn't working, and Ceria could hear Yvlon cursing as she struck the ground and Pisces taunted her. Ceria raised her arm, and then heard a voice.

"Not there."

She jerked, but it was Ksmvr. He was calling out to her across the room.

"To the left and down slightly."

Ceria didn't hesitate. She adjusted her aim and threw.

"You missed. A bit higher and more left."

Desperately, Ceria poured earth into her hands and added water. She molded a sopping mudball and took aim. She heard Yvlon cry out in pain and aimed desperately. She threw into the darkness.

"Ah—"

The light went out. Instantly, Ceria tore the blindfold away from her head. The world was absolute darkness.

"[Light]!"

This time, the flare of light was a dark green, and it didn't burn her eyes. Ceria looked around wildly, and saw two struggling shapes fighting over a sword.

The magic had ceased, at least for now, but the others were still insane. Ceria ran towards both of them and cried out as she raised her right hand.

"Stop! [Stone Fist]!"

Yvlon turned and raised her arm for only a second before the stone hand smashed into her chest. She fell backwards and Ceria turned and knocked Pisces backwards with a backhanded swipe. He stumbled back, staring at the gauntlet made of rock that covered Ceria's good hand.

"Magic? You dare? I'll make you suffer for this!"

His eyes were wild and he had Yvlon's sword. Ceria raised her skeletal hand warningly.

"Don't make me do this, Pisces."

"I told you, I'm not—"

"Ceria!"

Ksmvr appeared in a shower of bones. Pisces leapt back as a few flew towards him, and then narrowed his eyes at the Antinium. He said not a word, but charged with a wild cry. But Ceria was faster.

"[Ice Shard]."

The frozen icicle that shot from her finger flew as straight as an arrow, but the difference in this one was that the head was blunt, rather than sharp. It struck Pisces squarely in the forehead as he leapt at her, and he staggered. Ksmvr shoulder-charged him to the ground and struck him with one hand. Pisces sagged, and he went limp.

"Dead gods."

Ceria took one deep breath and then another. Ksmvr lowered Pisces to the ground as Ceria sat down hard—on a piece of bone. She yelped and tossed the yellowed thing across the room.

"Ceria Springwalker, are you well?"

"Me? I'm—fine."

She could taste blood and her lower lip had a hole in it. Her right shoulder still burned and Pisces had drawn blood with that damn bone. She was *not* fine, but other things were more important.

"Where's Yvlon?"

"Over there."

Ksmvr pointed and Ceria saw Yvlon standing and staring blankly ahead. The woman's blonde hair was matted with blood, and she had a deep cut down one cheek where Pisces must have struck her. But she didn't appear to notice any of that. She looked over haughtily as Ceria and Ksmvr approached.

"Yvlon?"

"I am Yelen Byres—"

"Rot, she's still under the spell."

Ceria sighed. Ksmvr looked uncertainly at Yvlon.

"Should we knock her out?"

"I beg your pardon?"

“No. I don’t think that’s wise. Let’s just tie her hands and legs up so she can’t hurt us if her personality changes again.”

“That is wise.”

Ksmvr approached Yvlon. The armored woman backed away, raising her voice in outrage.

“I’m sure I’ve never been so offended—unhand me, you—!”

She clawed at Ksmvr, but her two hands were no match for his three. In a few minutes he had her trussed up and lying in a clear part of the pit. Yvlon shouted angrily at them until Ceria stuffed her blindfold into the woman’s mouth. Yvlon spat it out and she began gnawing at the ropes like an animal. It wasn’t ideal, but at least it kept her occupied.

That done, Ceria had to take a few seconds just to breathe. While she was doing that, she finally took a good look around the pit she’d found herself in. The dark room was lit by her green light and it made the lurid piles of remains all the more disturbing.

Swords, bones, rotted fabric. The pit was a huge tomb of bodies, corpses and yellowed bones, all that remained of countless adventurers who’d been trapped here. Time had eaten away almost all the details of these fallen people, but Ceria could still see some clues as to how they’d died. A skull split by the worn shaft of an axe, a skeleton cut in two here, and one whose bones looked scorched—

“What a nightmare.”

Ceria shuddered as Ksmvr came to stand next to her. She looked at the Antinium and saw that he was holding his injured side, where a good section of his chitin had been picked away.

“Are you okay, Ksmvr?”

He nodded.

“I am only moderately inconvenienced, Captain. As soon as you covered the magical symbol I regained use of my mind.”

“Good. That’s...good.”

Ceria breathed in and out a few more times. She could still remember being insane, remember the sensation of losing all the structure in her head. She looked at Ksmvr, and then remembered she was still half-naked.

“Where are my pants? And my belt—did you see them, Ksmvr?”

He nodded.

“I removed them to construct your blindfold. My apologies. They are over here.”

The Antinium retrieved Ceria's possessions and she put her pants back on with a sigh of relief. The Antinium had cut a large strip out from one of the legs, but some clothing was better than none. She sat on the ground and began attaching her belt.

More importantly, with Ceria's belt came her water flask and the healing potion she'd brought. She greedily drank water from her flask while she offered the healing potion to Ksmvr. He applied half to his torn-up side and handed it back to Ceria. She hesitated, and then drank the potion rather than apply it to each of her wounds.

"Gah! That's foul."

Ceria tossed the empty bottle to one side and winced as it smashed. Ksmvr hesitated, and then sat next to her.

"That was a most dangerous trap we were caught in."

"You think?"

"I do."

The half-Elf shook her head.

"We nearly died. If it hadn't been for my heritage and luck—how long were we under the spell?"

"I cannot say."

Beside her, Ksmvr shifted to look at Ceria. His normally impassive voice changed slightly, grew a bit uncertain.

"Do you believe that spell will affect Pisces and Yvlon for much longer?"

"I don't know."

Ceria rubbed at her face.

"Maybe? It might wear off soon, but you never know. At least it wasn't real insanity that hit us, just the spell."

"Oh?"

Ksmvr looked at her. Ceria nodded tiredly, feeling the healing potion getting to work on the rest of her body.

"It's just the magical effect. Real insanity—you'd have to be a better mage to really create madness in people. This is just...an approximation. The spell reaches into your head and messes up your world. It's close, but not the same."

"I see. That would explain my experience."

The Antinium nodded a few times as he sat next to Ceria. He hesitated, and then cleared his throat awkwardly.

“If the spell had created true insanity in me, I would have become Aberration at once. And then I would have killed all three of you within seconds.”

Ceria just looked at him. How was she supposed to respond to that? But maybe that was Ksmvr’s way of saying he was glad things had worked out. She thought for a second, and then looked at the place where he’d sliced her pants apart.

“Ksmvr? You said you made the blindfold for me?”

He nodded. Cautiously.

“Yes. I was...unable to do more. I regret my failure to act, but—”

“Good job.”

“Oh. Thank you.”

Ceria and Ksmvr sat in silence for over twenty minutes before Pisces woke up. He came to with a shout of surprise, which turned into a groan.

“My *head*...”

He didn’t appear to be insane, but Ceria and Ksmvr were ready for anything as he staggered upright. Pisces took one look around at them, at the bones, and the foul pit they were in, and then he asked if they had anything to eat. That reassured them he was back to normal.

Ceria had a thing about bones, in that she didn’t like seeing them, especially if they were her bones. Add that to the general unsanitary nature of the pit, with the black foreign substance crusting every part of the room, and she was feeling quite unhappy with their current predicament. But Pisces seemed to regard the dead bodies as mere furnishings, and he happily crammed some dried meat into his mouth.

“So you and Ksmvr eliminated the spell? Most efficacious. Allow me to congratulate the both of you. I was completely subsumed by the enchantment. What was my reaction to the [Insanity] spell, incidentally?”

“You thought you were your father.”

Pisces paused mid-chew.

“Ah.”

“And you tried to run both me and Yvlon through.”

“I apologize for that. I am relieved I was so ineffectual.”

He chewed the rest of his bite slowly, and swallowed, no longer looking quite as pleased. Pisces glanced over to Yvlon. She was still drooling on the bindings on her wrist, looking more than a little rabid.

“...Perhaps we should leave before your mud wears off. I would not like to repeat such a harrowing experience.”

Ceria nodded. That was her first thought too, but...

“How the hell are we going to get out?”

The pit was dark, and as far as she could see, the walls extended upwards at least thirty feet. If there was a ceiling, it wasn't within her [Light] spell's cone of illumination.

Pisces looked up. He frowned and conjured a ball of light himself and threw it upwards.

“Let's find out.”

His orb glowed with pure white light. Ksmvr and Ceria both saw it fly upwards, and then break—splash, really, the light becoming fading motes—across a dirt ceiling. Ceria groaned and Pisces made a similar noise of displeasure.

“We're trapped.”

Pisces nodded, looking unhappy.

“Who knows how deep we are? We could dig up for years and not reach the surface.”

“Not necessarily.”

Both mages looked at Ksmvr. The Antinium nodded as he stared upwards.

“There must be an entrance higher up. Companion Pisces, if you recast your spell, I believe we may be able to identify an opening.”

“What makes you assume that, Ksmvr?”

Ceria looked curiously at the Antinium. He looked back at her without a shred of doubt as he replied.

“If this room were truly a sealed chamber, we and those who have preceded us would have quickly used up the supply of air within the room. The fact that we did not suffocate instantly indicates an air source of some kind.”

“Oh.”

Pisces looked at Ceria and then both mages threw orbs of [Light] upwards again. After a minute of studying the ceiling, Ksmvr exclaimed and pointed.

“There.”

Pisces squinted upwards, frowning.

“Are you certain? I cannot see anything.”

“My eyes are used to the dark. There is an opening there. If we dig, we will most likely find some sort of passageway.”

“So now we just have to get to it. Any ideas?”

Ceria eyed the smooth walls doubtfully. Aside from the black coating, the stone looked unblemished. Pisces just smirked as he stroked his chin.

“This issue should be easily surmounted. Allow me to rectify my earlier deficiency.”

He clicked his fingers, and Ceria felt the room move. Not the ground or the walls, but everything else in it. The bones of the countless dead began to *shift*.

“Pisces?”

He just smiled as yellowed bones began flying into the air and upwards. Ksmvr stared at the shifting bones without comment, but on the ground Yvlon stopped biting at her robes and screamed.

“*Necromancer!* Kill him at once!”

“Oh hush.”

Pisces frowned and pointed at Yvlon. Two piles of bones stood up and became skeletons. They walked over to hold her down as she wriggled and tried to break free of her bindings.

“No! Don’t touch me! Stop!”

She wailed—Ceria had never heard Yvlon make any sound like that before—as the skeletons held her in place. Yvlon thrashed wildly, but she was unable to break free. The real Yvlon might have mustered the strength, but Yelen Byres, whoever she was, was a weak noblewoman who couldn’t do a thing.

And meanwhile, the other bones were floating in the air, rearranging themselves. They weren’t forming a creature—instead, Ceria saw with horrified fascination, they were forming a staircase. Small bones and big ones ordered themselves into smooth ledges, and, step-by-step, an ivory staircase built itself upwards, leading to the spot Ksmvr had indicated.

Pisces wiped some sweat off his forehead and exhaled a few times as the last bone flew into the horrific set of steps. He smiled cheerfully at Ceria and Ksmvr, both of whom were giving him the fisheye.

“There. We have a way up, and the means to dig as well.”

“I guess?”

Ceria looked uneasily at the staircase. She did *not* like Necromancy, but neither was she stupid enough to turn down a good solution. Ksmvr just stared at the bones and nodded.

“Efficient.”

Only Yvlon was upset. She screamed at the skeletons as they lifted her up, staggering under the weight of her armor. Pisces frowned—he waved his hand and several more skeletons stood up out of the collection of bones still littering the floor.

“It appears that this trap, however temporarily detrimental to our health, has one unexpected benefit. I can conjure as many skeletons as I need to from this supply.”

“And you won’t run out of mana? I know you’ve got to be tired, and we don’t exactly have any mana potions to spare.”

Ceria looked doubtfully at Pisces. He hesitated.

“I have used quite a bit. But it seems wiser to expend my resources in creating more undead to aid us, especially given our weakened states.”

“True. Okay, summon as many as you can.”

“These five will do for now. I shall begin digging upwards, unless Ksmvr thinks it will cause a collapse?”

Ksmvr studied the dirt roof and shook his head.

“It should be fine.”

“Very well then.”

Pisces pointed upwards, at the small dark crevice in the ceiling. Two skeletons ran up the staircase and began digging energetically at the spot, showering dirt into the pit below. They were holding rusted blades and pieces of metal—the remains of some of the adventurer’s gear.

“It should take them just a little while to clear the obstruction!”

Pisces shouted down cheerily as he walked up to supervise his skeletons. Ceria shook her head as she found a place to sit on the now-cleared floor of the pit. She wasn’t going up that staircase more than once; solid it may be, but Pisces had opted not to build guardrails, and the bones hovered in the air without any solid supports. It was an amazing piece of magic, but it still made her queasy to imagine climbing it.

She’d have to in the end, but that was later. To take her mind off of that, Ceria looked around. Now that the ground was clear, she saw something that had been buried under a pile of bones. Cautiously, Ceria walked over to

it. It was dark and bulky, and at first she thought it was a part of an adventurer that had yet to rot. But this wasn't meat. Instead, Ceria found dark, rough fabric. She cast another [Light] spell and saw what it was clearly.

It was an adventurer's pack, still neatly secured to the skeleton of its owner. Ceria hesitated, and then shifted the bones aside and lifted the bag. It was quite heavy.

"Ksmvr, here's something else. Can you take it?"

The Antinium walked over and hoisted the pack easily. Ceria nodded to him, and then heard a shout from above.

"I see light! We're right below the tunnel we uncovered!"

Both adventurers below sighed in relief. Pisces grinned at them from above, and then shouted.

"Watch out!"

They saw a skeleton falling from above, brought down by a cascade of dirt. Pisces blew away the dirt around him with a barrier of air and Ceria and Ksmvr covered Yvlon, shielding their heads as the skeleton struck the floor of the pit and *shattered*.

"Are you okay?"

"Fine!"

Ksmvr shouted up as Ceria looked around. The flailing skeleton hadn't done any damage to the staircase, but her blood ran cold when she saw something glinting on the side of the pit.

"Dead gods! Watch the sides!"

Pisces looked down and *swore*. The flailing skeleton had, in its fall, struck the black, encrusted wall of the pit. In doing so, he'd knocked some of the unnamed substance free, and glowing behind the covering was the unmistakable symbol of the [Insanity] spell.

Both Ceria and Pisces reacted with the speed of panic. She threw mud and he blew a cloud of dust in front of the spell before it could work on them. The partially visible runes disappeared as Ceria hurled more mud to cover it and stopped, panting heavily.

"That was quite dangerous."

"You think?"

Ceria wiped cold sweat from her forehead as she stared at the spot. She looked around the pit and shuddered as she suddenly realized the true nature of the trap.

“Runes underneath...? All the walls must be covered in the [Insanity] spell.”

Ksmvr looked around.

“Truly? That would be a most dangerous effect. It is fortunate that previous adventurers managed to coat the walls.”

“You’re telling me. If we’d been exposed to the spell from all sides, we wouldn’t have had a chance.”

Ceria wondered what the black substance was. She looked down at a flake of it on the ground. It was almost like tar—although spread quite thin. It couldn’t be magic; even the best spells faded after time. An [Alchemist]’s concoction of some kind? Whoever it was, Ceria gave her quiet thanks to them for doing what they had.

“I see light! The tunnel’s wide enough! I’m going up!”

Pisces shouted down to Ksmvr and Ceria after a few more minutes of dirt falling. She raised a hand in acknowledgment.

“Be careful!”

Pisces disappeared above. After a few seconds, he poked his head down.

“Come on up! Ascend carefully—my skeletons will help you!”

Ceria and Ksmvr didn’t need the help of the skeletons to walk upwards, although they did move quite slowly and deliberately to avoid slipping. But Yvlon had to be dragged up by three skeletons, all of them holding her as tightly as possible as she cursed and struggled, oblivious to the drop.

It was a small tunnel that Pisces’ skeletons had dug upwards. They’d followed the already-existing passageway and broken into the very same tunnel where Ceria and the other Horns of Hammerad had been walking earlier. Pisces pulled Ceria out of the pit, coughing as she shook herself to get most of the dirt off. Ksmvr easily clambered out of the ground and helped the skeletons pull Yvlon up. She was still screaming curses at Pisces.

“Foul [Necromancer]! My father will have your head for your sorcery, do you hear me? If it’s a ransom you want, he’ll pay it. Only do not touch a hair on my head! The Byres family will not tolerate any—”

“I am concerned about comrade Yvlon’s mental state, Captain.”

Ksmvr calmly held a hand over Yvlon’s mouth. She shouted into his hand as he addressed Ceria.

“She has not awoken from the effects of the spell. Should we knock her out to aid in that process?”

Ceria shook her head as she looked around.

“She’s not a [Mage] like Pisces or me, and she doesn’t have...whatever you have, Ksmvr. The spell will take longer to wear off, but I’m sure it will in time.”

“I see. Then, what should we do? Press on or wait?”

“Can we just—wait a second?”

Ceria panted as she sat down on the smooth, wonderfully solid stone floor. Pisces sat down as well, and after a pause, so did Ksmvr.

“We’re alive. We were in the worst of traps but—we’re alive.”

Pisces and Ksmvr nodded. Yvlon drooled on the ground around Ksmvr’s hand. Ceria sighed. She lay back on the ground, stretching out. She wanted to shake and cry and laugh and vomit. They’d made it. It wasn’t the first time she’d gotten out of a hairy situation but this—

This had been one of the worst. And they’d done it as a team. No one had died. For a few minutes, ten, really, she just lay there. Then Pisces coughed.

“As unpleasant as that last obstacle was, it occurs to me that we must have been underground for a long time. Hours, perhaps.”

“Days?”

“Maybe. I cannot be certain. But it is clear that we have two options as of now. We can either retreat and regroup with the knowledge of these advanced deterrents, or...we can advance.”

He pointed. Ceria looked, and saw the door. The damn *door*. They’d come out in the last part of the passageway, almost directly in front of the door that had sent them into the trap in the first place.

“You’re telling me that thing just teleported us down?”

“It’s the most efficient use of mana. It only makes sense.”

Ksmvr nodded.

“It is a formidable obstacle, but now that we have uncovered the danger, is it worth moving forwards? We are nearly out of food, and we all require rest.”

“What do you think, Ceria?”

The half-Elf looked up at Pisces. He looked down at her, quite innocently. But there was a gleam in his eyes. He knew what she was about to say. She sat up and stared at the plain wooden door. Then she looked at the other mage.

“Pisces?”

“Yes, oh Captain of mine?”

“Get your skeletons to grab whatever weapons they can and break down that damn door.”

“It would be my pleasure.”

An hour later, the door fell in. It wasn't because the wood had been shattered by the constant hammering on it, or that the four adventurers had cast any particular spell to break it. No, the reason the door broke was simple: the skeletons had chipped away at the stone around the hinges set in the wall until the masonry cracked, and the door obeyed the forces of gravity.

The four skeletons that had done all of the work stepped back, rusted blades in hand as three adventurers peeked into the opening, coughing as the small dust cloud that had been raised temporarily obscured all vision.

Pisces, Ceria, and Ksmvr stood behind the wall of skeletons, ready for anything. They were exhausted, hurt, and hungry, but all were sure this was the final barrier, and they were determined to be here. And they were all alive. The only incapacitated member of their team they'd left a few feet away, wrapped up in a blanket.

Yvlon lay on the ground, shuddering. She was safe, but not up to any further exploring for the moment. She was still gibbering a bit, but she had stopped assuming different personalities and better, she had regained bowel control. It had deserted her in a rather unfortunate way as she slowly came out of the effects of the [Insanity] spell.

Now the three adventurers tensed, waiting for the cloud to clear. They expected another trap, or maybe an antechamber, the beginning of another part of the hallway, but then the dust cleared and they saw the light.

It wasn't sunlight, or artificial light, but rather, the golden glow as the light from outside touched something in the room and made it shimmer. Ceria lowered her skeletal hand and breathed out. Slowly.

“Oh dead gods.”

The fallen door had revealed only a small chamber at the end of all these deadly traps. It was a small room. Yes, a small room, but one filled with one thing. The thing all adventurers dreamed of.

Treasure.

Pisces and Ceria gaped in wonder, their eyes nearly popping out of their heads. Peeking around one of the motionless skeletons, Ksmvr nodded in approval.

“I see quite a number of swords. This is considered good, correct?”

In truth, the room couldn't have been more than twenty feet across, and it was certainly narrower than it was long. It was the storage closet of treasure vaults, but the quality set it apart. Ceria and Pisces could see it in the glimmering aura that manifested itself the instant they laid eyes on the treasure.

“Look at it!”

Ceria half-screamed as she pointed. The room was small, but it had a rack of weapons that first caught the eye. Glimmering weapons and metal that didn't look like any ore Ceria had ever seen before hung in the form of swords, daggers, even a battleaxe.

On the other wall a bookshelf full of clearly magical tomes stood, a treasure in itself. A mage's library. But that wasn't all. Glittering gold coins and gems occupied the back of the treasure room glowing and glimmering in the adventurer's light. But what drew Ceria's attention was the small desk, the magical tome and small bag sitting next to it, and the staff almost casually propped up against the wall.

Any other eye might have been drawn to the gold, or like Ksmvr to the artifacts in the forms of weaponry. But both mages only had eyes for the staff. They saw what others could not; the magic that emanated from the object like a beacon.

“The staff. I can't believe it! Can you see the aura, Springwalker? Can you see the power in it?”

“I can! I can! It radiates—just look, Ksmvr!”

“I see swords. Where is the staff?”

It was actually a staff in two parts. Twisted metal—or was it stone?—snaked upwards, dividing, becoming thin tendrils of metal which eventually tapered off into nothing. A foot of space, and then the tendrils reappeared, moving in the opposite direction, reaching the top of the staff which was set with a huge aquamarine gemstone. The two pieces of the staff were perfectly connected, as if there was steel in the place of air.

“It even *looks* magical. Ancestors, look at it.”

“I have to touch it.”

Pisces breathed the words and Ceria thought the exact same thing. Ksmvr looked doubtfully around the room.

“Should we check for traps first?”

Neither mage heard him. They ran forwards, jostling each other. Ksmvr walked after them, staring around.

“I would like to try one of the swords. Do you think that would be acceptable?”

Pisces and Ceria ignored Ksmvr. They practically fought each other to be the first into the room, both reaching for the staff.

“Intruders.”

The voice was soft, but full of malice. Both Pisces and Ceria froze, hands reaching for the staff. They looked around, and saw something appearing in the center of the room.

Flames licked into being, and then coalesced. Air became fire, and the fire itself knitted together to become a solid thing, a shape, a figure made out of the white-hot flames. A man, or what looked vaguely like a man, stepped out of the air and stared at Pisces, Ceria, and Ksmvr.

“You are trespassing in the personal sanctuary of Warmage Thresk. Identify yourselves or be destroyed.”

“Oh no.”

Ceria breathed the words, her heart tight in her chest. They’d forgotten. In their haste, they’d forgotten the golden rule of adventuring. Never let your guard down at the end. That’s when the worst trap starts.

The fiery creation looked at her, eyes burning blue in its formless face.

“Who are you? Why do you enter this place? Answer, or I will burn you asunder.”

Something was burning in the center of its chest. A jewel? Ceria squinted at it as Pisces stammered a reply.

“We are ah, *Wistram* mages, here to consult with Warmage Thresk on a matter of great importance. We apologize if we are disturbing—”

“Lies.”

The fiery eyes burned. The construct opened a mouth and showed them insides full of red flames that burned against his incendiary white-hot exterior.

“No one may enter this place save for Warmage Thresk or those of his blood. You are thieves. You will be burnt to ash.”

He raised a hand and extended it towards the three. All at once, the heat in the room grew until it was practically an inferno by itself. Ceria shouted at the same time Pisces did. Both mages extended their palms out.

“[Frozen Wind]!”

The spell blew freezing cold air towards the apparition for a moment. Just for a moment, that was all. It barely halted the rising temperature of the room, but it gave the two mages and Ksmvr the moment they needed to dash out of the room before they were cooked in their skins. Ceria gasped as she ran down the corridor; her skin felt *burnt* from the second they’d been in the room.

“Pisces! Use the skeletons!”

“Right. Defend me!”

He called out to the skeletons as the three adventurers rushed past them. The skeletons charged the fiery being—and immediately turned to ash as they got too close. Ceria didn’t even bother to swear; she just pumped her arms and legs faster.

“[Frozen Wind] had no effect!”

She screamed at Pisces. He shouted back, face pale.

“I know! That thing’s way too powerful! We have to retreat!”

“*There is no escape!*”

Flames burst out of the ground in front of them. Pisces, Ceria, and Ksmvr skidded to a halt as the fire wall blocked off their exit. This was no ordinary [Fire Wall] spell either; the flames were not just red or orange, but white-hot like the construct, and the stone *cracked* and melted where the fire touched.

“Dead gods.”

They turned and saw the apparition of flames. It was walking towards them, slowly, nonchalantly, as if it had all the time in the world. Ceria grabbed Pisces’s arm.

“Do you have any spells you can use?”

“Me? You’re the ice specialist! You do something about it!”

Ceria gulped. The hallway was large enough to dodge the flaming being, but he was walking faster now. He was reaching out to them, and a sword of blue flames grew in his hands.

“Ksmvr, Pisces! Distract it!”

“*Me?*”

“Acknowledged.”

Pisces gaped at her. But Ceria was backing up. Ksmvr ran forwards and slashed at the monster—his sword melted before he got close and he stumbled away, *keening* in distress. Just the proximity to the fiery being had cracked his carapace with the heat.

“Pisces!”

He gulped but ran towards the fiery being. It swung the sword at him, but Pisces took a step and his form *blurred*. He dashed around the construct, nimbly avoiding it as it swung twice more.

[Flash Step]. It was one of Pisces’ old spells, and Ceria was relieved to see he hadn’t forgotten how to use it. Pisces danced back, keeping a very large distance away from the fiery being as he let it approach him. He dodged and wove back and forth with nimble steps, careful not to let it corner him in the corridor.

“A spell would greatly be appreciated, Springwalker!”

Ceria didn’t even bother to reply. She was focusing, trying to call upon all the mana she had left for an attack.

Her best spell was [Ice Spike], but if she concentrated, Ceria could fire one shot from all five fingers. She drew mana into her skeletal hand, calling on all her reserves.

The apparition lunged forwards, and Ceria heard Pisces scream. The fiery blade hadn’t touched him, but the creation had moved too close and Pisces had been burned by the heat emanating from the being. He leapt away with the [Flash Step] spell and then collapsed against a wall, moaning. Tendrils of smoke rose from his burnt side and hundreds of blisters appeared like magic on his arms and legs.

“You will be burnt.”

The construct walked forwards, blue eyes burning. Ceria shouted.

“Turn and face *me*, you damn Golem!”

It turned. There was no fear in the construct’s eyes as it saw Ceria approaching. It raised its sword and lowered itself to charge, but Ceria didn’t give it time to do so. She raised her hand and shouted.

“[Ice Spike]!”

Five wicked shards of ice, each as long as Ceria’s arm burst from her hand, shooting out like ballista bolts at the fiery apparition. The ice flew towards the flaming creature, struck his outer flames, and *screamed* as the ice evaporated into steam instantly. The fiery construct blinked once, his flames not even dampened by the spell.

“Oh Ancestors.”

Ceria backed away from him. The construct advanced, sword at its side. It had no fear of her, not even wariness.

“You will perish.”

“Not her. Turn and face me first!”

This shout came from the side. Ceria heard what almost sounded like a sigh coming from the fiery thing, and then it turned. Yvlon stood with her shield and sword in hand, facing the apparition fearlessly.

“Face me, thing. I will not run from you.”

Ceria’s heart leapt in her chest, but her mouth opened to shout a warning as she scrambled backwards, away from the fiery being.

“Don’t block its flames! It’ll burn through your armor!”

Yvlon heard the warning as the creation hurled white flames at her. She dropped her shield and rolled. The fire missed her, but from the way Yvlon cried out, Ceria knew she had to have felt the intense heat of the fire.

“There’s no way to block against it!”

“The door.”

Pisces moaned and Ceria saw that he and Ksmvr had pulled themselves into the small room. The construct froze, and then he seemed to grow larger, as if in rage.

“No one may enter the treasury.”

“Then come and stop us if you can!”

Pisces shouted, and the guardian obliged. He hurled more fire, but this time Ksmvr and Yvlon pulled the door up, the door that had proved unbreakable, and blocked the fire. The white flames dissipated as they struck the innocuous wood, and the guardian *hissed*.

It was distracted, and ignoring Ceria for the moment. But she was caught between a hot place and the wall of flames it had created. She glanced at them as she stared at the guardian. Nowhere to run. But she wasn’t about to abandon her friends.

Think. The construct had to be powered by something. No spell could ever power such a being for long, not without the mage supplying mana. Then where was its power source?

The thing she’d spotted in the chest. Ceria squinted as the construct advanced. Was it—yes there it was! She saw something glowing in the chest. Some sort of mana stone. But how could she strike it?

The construct hurled fire, but Yvlon ducked behind the wooden door she was using like a shield. She darted out, baiting the construct as it swung at her, but dove backwards again. She couldn't get near enough to strike, not that her sword would have hurt the guardian, but she was occupying it as it advanced. In a few seconds though, they would be cornered.

If only they could bypass the flames—

“Use the door!”

Ceria screamed at the others. The guardian turned its head, but she pointed, heedless of the danger.

“There's a gem in its chest! Use the door and smash it!”

“Got it!”

The three adventurers backed away from the construct, holding the door as a shield in front of them. It hesitated, aware of the power of the door to mitigate its flames.

“You will not stop—”

All three Horns of Hammerad shouted as they rushed towards the construct, pushing the door forwards like a huge shield. At the last moment, before they got too close and were burnt alive, they let go of the door. Ksmvr kicked it forwards, and the massive wooden section of wood fell slowly towards the flaming guardian.

The fiery being took one look at the falling door—

And dodged. He stepped swiftly to one side, avoiding it. Not swiftly enough; the door crushed his left side and the guardian *howled* in what sounded like true agony. But he was not dead. Ceria saw the gemstone in his chest, a pulsating emerald stone the size of her fist. But already the flames were swirling around it, growing, rebuilding his body.

“For Byres and honor!”

Yvlon shouted as she charged forwards. Ceria saw Ksmvr and Pisces trying to drag her back, but the armored woman ran at the fiery guardian. It raised its flaming sword, but she cut through it. Her own silvery sword was mere metal, but for a brief second before it evaporated, the metal was still strong. And it struck the gem at the construct's source.

“*Aaah!*”

Ceria heard Yvlon's scream first, right above the *crack* of the gem breaking.

She howled as her silver armor glowed red. The sword melted as it dropped from her hands and she stumbled away. Her silver armor was

melting over her hands, making the young woman scream.

And the construct howled too. It reached for the gem, and then it faltered. The flames in its eyes went out. It tried to step towards Ceria, stumbled. Then it looked up at her and roared.

“If the secret of this place cannot be protected, then everything will be destroyed. And you will perish with it!”

It stood up, and stumbled back into the treasury room. Ceria shouted.
“No!”

But it was too late. The construct fell to the ground, and the white hot flames began to spread. It was engulfing the room! The flames were spreading, reaching outwards into the corridor. The guardian was trying to burn the treasure—and the Horns of Hammerad with it.

“Get away, everyone! We have to run!”

Pisces and Ksmvr ran away from the intense heat, shouting in pain. They grabbed Yvlon, who was still clawing at her smoking arms, and pulled her towards Ceria. She turned to run—

And saw the white-hot flames, still burning, a solid wall blocking their escape. The flames had diminished somewhat, but they were still so hot that Ceria knew touching them would sear her to the bone in seconds.

Pisces and Ksmvr stopped beside her, burnt and smoking. They stared in horror at the flames blocking the entrance, and then at the fire slowly engulfing the treasury room, making its way down the corridor towards them.

“What do we do, Captain? A spell?”

“One of the walls?”

“We can’t tunnel through that!”

“The trap below!”

Pisces shouted, and Ceria looked. Yes, there! The opening in the floor was still visible. She grabbed Yvlon’s legs—the woman couldn’t even move as she still screamed, and all three adventurers ran towards it.

Ceria nearly fell off the bone staircase, but Ksmvr caught her and they rushed down the stairs, already feeling the heat overhead. Ksmvr and Pisces laid Yvlon on the floor and she screamed again, trying to pull her melted armor off. But the metal had *fused*, and her arms were still smoking. Ceria caught her breath and reached for a potion, but Ksmvr was faster. He poured it over her arms and into her mouth while Pisces poured the last of their water over Yvlon’s arms. Steam rose and she stopped thrashing.

She was alive, for now. Ceria diverted her attention upwards. She could still sense the heat, and she knew the flames were spreading. And that fire—it was magical flames, of a Tier she'd never seen before. It would burn away everything upstairs. The treasure, the swords—everything.

“No, no, *no!* We were so close! It can't end like this!”

Ceria shouted in despair, but she knew better than to go up. Ksmvr reached for her, but Ceria knocked his hand away. She hammered the ground as she screamed in desperation.

“It won't end.”

Pisces' voice made Ceria look up. The mage was standing, robes burnt, skin blistered, but determined. A fierce look was in his eyes and he raised both arms up, his voice growing deeper.

“Arise! Arise and heed my call! Go into the depths of flame and bring me a ransom of gold and magic! Go now, treasure seekers! Go, fallen comrades!”

The room trembled. Every bone in the room—from the staircases to the bones Pisces had left untouched, began to *shift* and come together. Skeletons rose up, and began running the instant they were formed, before they were even fully formed. Ceria stared as they dashed up the staircase of bone. Up.

She knew what they had to be doing. The skeletons dashed into the room and snatched up burning objects, heedless of the flames that *cracked* their very bones. Over half fell before they could return, their bones catching fire and literally disintegrating from the heat.

But some—yes, some made it out of the room, and what they took was scooped up by other bony hands, brought back. Burning skeletons fell down from above and Ceria and Ksmvr shielded their faces as burning bone fragments crashed to the ground around them. More skeletons ran up, and Pisces shouted, his hands pointed up as sweat poured from his brow. He gasped, pointing, as more skeletons emerged, even more burnt than before, falling into the pit.

And then the fire grew more intense, and not a single skeleton returned. Ceria saw the last burst into flames even as he climbed up into the tunnel above, and Pisces collapsed on the ground. Ceria rushed over to him and found the mage breathing hoarsely.

“The heat—”

It was growing hot. So hot. Ceria lay down on the cool stone and saw Ksmvr cradling Yvlon. Her arms—didn't look right. Melted silver intertwined with flesh, and she was unconscious. Pisces lay on the ground next to the burnt bone. Slowly, Ceria looked around.

Scattered objects. Burnt things, barely recognizable. A cracked sword, blackened by soot. A buckler almost cut in half.

Worthless things. And no staff. Ceria despaired, and felt her eyes stinging. If she had water in her to cry, she might have. But then she saw a skeletal hand, holding something. Ceria crawled over to it, and saw a burnt tome.

A book. Its cover was gone, and half the pages. Ceria brushed aside white ash and saw a page and glowing symbols. She clutched it to her, holding it dearly as the heat grew even worse, and air became a luxury, then a memory.

Slowly, Ksmvr collapsed to the ground, still holding Yvlon. Pisces didn't move, and the stairway of bone fell to the ground. Ceria didn't even look up as something struck her back. She couldn't. She just held the book and breathed in. Out. In. Out. In—

It was so hot.

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She woke up quietly, without screaming. Ceria opened her eyes and sat up. She was in pain, but she didn't cry out. She just took a deep, wavering breath in the silence of the pit and knew she was alive.

Her skin felt burnt. Not just burnt; *damaged*. The heat from above had cooked her like an egg. But she was still alive, so it was clear that the magical flames from above hadn't managed to spread to below.

The half-Elf sighed, and felt something move on her chest. She looked down and saw the book. Part of it was white ash that fell away as she lifted it up. But the other half—

“Ah.”

It was magical. The page that lay exposed under the dust shone, the intricate, spider-web writing that made up the magical spells glowing like saffron under her gaze. Ceria breathed lightly and the ash fell away. She looked at the spell and felt the magic reach out to her, whispering. For a second Ceria just looked at the third of the spellbook and believed in magic, believed in legends and dreams and even heroes. Then she put the book down and looked for her friends.

“[Light].”

The shimmering azure orb cast into light the fragments of scorched bone, the black tar-like substance on the walls, and the armored young woman sitting cross-legged in the center of the destruction. Yvlon sat silently, head bowed, staring in quiet contemplation at her arms. Her golden hair shone slightly, but the reflection off the melted silver of her arms shone even brighter. It flowed, like an ocean of metal.

“Yvlon.”

The other woman didn't look up as Ceria staggered over. She just lifted her arms—with effort.

“It's fused to my skin, Ceria. I can feel it. I could take off the rest of my armor but this—this isn't so easy to undo.”

She had indeed taken off the rest of her plate armor. It lay scattered around her, badly deformed, parts melted together such that Yvlon had had to take off the entire section at once. But the metal on her arms remained.

Ceria caught her breath as she saw how badly the metal had melted. It was twisted, warped, and clung to Yvlon's arms like—

"We can cut it off. Even if we have to heal some of it afterwards—"

"Some will come off. But the rest—it feels deep, Ceria."

Yvlon shook her head. Her arms moved as she—slowly—flexed them. Ceria saw breaks along the elbows and wrist sections, enough for Yvlon to move her arms. But the metal was clearly anchored to Yvlon's flesh.

"We'll get it off. We just need to get back to the city."

Yvlon nodded slowly. She smiled, only a trace of bitterness in her eyes.

"I always wondered how Dullahans lived. I guess I'll learn a bit of what it's like."

"I—"

There was nothing to say. Ceria bent down and clasped Yvlon's shoulder. After a moment, she felt a cold, hard hand grasp hers.

"You saved us all. You slew a being made of pure flame with a sword. You'd be a hero among adventurers just for that."

"Father would be proud."

The Human woman laughed. Ceria forced her lips to move, smiled. Then she looked around.

"Pisces and Ksmvr?"

"Over there. Pisces looks worst off—I'd have woken you, but I thought it was better if you rested."

Ceria nodded and brushed at her sooty hair. She staggered a bit—she felt empty.

"How long was I out?"

"I was only up for the last twenty minutes. Before that? It must be hours, at least. I can't sense any heat from above."

"True."

Ceria nodded, and then walked over to Pisces and Ksmvr. The two were lying not far from each other. And of the two, Pisces was clearly worse-off. The mage had vomit staining his lips and he had gotten some of it on himself. He was pale and shivering, and Ceria knew he had to be suffering. She pulled out a bottle from her belt. It was still intact. The thick glass had protected the mana potion.

Carefully, Ceria poured the maroon liquid over Pisces, ignoring his reactions. It didn't matter too much if he drank it; right now his body was a

void of mana, and he would absorb it from the concentrated liquid to recover.

Sure enough, Pisces sat up, gasping. The noise woke up Ksmvr as well. The two sat up; Ksmvr dribbled a bit of green from his mouth, but wiped it away. Ceria wasn't sure if that was blood or something worse. No one was in good shape at the moment.

"Pisces, are you okay?"

"I—"

The mage's face was pale. He dry-heaved a bit, and then wiped at his mouth. He regarded the stains on his robe and shuddered before looking up at Ceria.

"Mana potion?"

She nodded. Ksmvr staggered upright and saluted Ceria weakly.

"Captain."

"Take it easy, Ksmvr."

"I will do so. Is comrade Pisces alright?"

"I think so, but he was insane. You know that, right, Pisces? You reanimated what, over thirty skeletons in a ten minute period? You're lucky you didn't start bleeding in the brain or damage yourself worse."

"I am a better [Necromancer] than I am a [Mage] by far."

That was all Pisces said, which meant he pretty much agreed with Ceria's statement. He looked around the pit full of bone fragments and closed his eyes.

"...Did we manage to save *anything*?"

"I found part of a spell book. Besides that, I don't know. Yvlon's not in a good way."

The other two adventurers followed Ceria over to Yvlon. She looked up and nodded at them. Pisces stared at her arms openly, while Ksmvr looked at them and around the room.

"What should we do now, Captain Ceria? Should we begin collecting valuable items? I still have the pack you gave me."

"I—"

Ceria just shook her head. She could barely stand, and she saw Pisces was swaying on his feet.

"Ten minutes. Let's just..."

She sat down wearily, and then had to lie down. Pisces collapsed back onto the ground; Ksmvr stayed on his feet and began to wander the pit,

picking up burnt objects. Yvlon went back to staring at her arms.

It took a while for Ceria to feel strong enough to get back up. When she did, she just felt like lying down again. But they had to move.

“Okay. Pisces, you’re our only ticket out of this pit. Can you make another staircase?”

The [Mage] looked up tiredly at the small gap high overhead.

“I can try.”

It was a mark of his exhaustion that he didn’t brag, and Ceria knew it. She helped him up.

“Do it slowly. Piece by piece. You don’t have to complete it in one go.”

He nodded. Ceria turned to Ksmvr.

“While Pisces is working, let’s get some of the stuff that fell into the pit gathered up. Most of it looks burned, but they’re all highly magical artifacts. Put anything you can find over here, okay Ksmvr?”

The Antinium had already accumulated a few burnt objects. He gently edged them closer to Yvlon, but the other woman was standing up. She moved her arms stiffly, and then nodded.

“I’ll help too.”

“You don’t have to, Yvlon—”

“I can do it. I need to move.”

She began moving around the edge of the pit. Ceria hesitated, and then got to work as well. The first thing she did was pick up the spellbook. The magic words glimmered as she put the book in her pack. Then she began hunting for anything that had survived the flames.

“Burnt sword here. Looks cracked. But it’s still magical; I can feel it.”

“Are such objects repairable, Captain?”

“I have no idea. And I don’t even know what these things do, so handle them carefully, alright?”

“I will do so.”

Ceria placed the sword on the ground next to a pack. She stared at it blankly until she remembered it was the adventurer’s pack she’d found. What could be inside there?

Whatever it was, it would have to wait until later. Some adventurers trapped their belongings in case they were stolen, and Ceria wanted to risk nothing. She looked at Pisces, and saw he was beginning to build the bridge out of the burnt bones again.

This time, the construction process was painfully slow. Ceria could see Pisces grimacing as bones slowly flew into the air. He could only manage about eight at a time. But he was getting the job done, and he looked determined not to quit.

It was a different side of him than Ceria had seen, and once again it reminded her of the past. She paused as she sorted through a few bones next to Pisces.

“That was some final guardian, wasn’t it?”

Pisces nodded, not taking his eyes off his work.

“It was a formidable enemy. I regret that neither you nor I had the forethought to check for traps at the last moment.”

She nodded, biting her lip.

“Although if the mage was any good, he would have set the summoning spell to activate if we checked the magic, just like the door.”

“True.”

Silence. Ceria tossed a long bone up and watched it float upwards.

“Did it remind you of anything? The fire construct, I mean.”

“Are you referring to the Golems of Wistram? That is a natural comparison, but unfair. This...creature was clearly meant to be summoned for short periods rather than act as a permanent servant. True, it was far less intelligent than Cognita. It was simply a guardian, meant to kill.”

“It was good enough at that. I just wonder...how’d it catch you? You’re better than that, or you should be.”

The young man stopped in his work. He lowered his hands and stared at Ceria. His eyes were cold.

“What do you mean by that?”

“Exactly what I said. Don’t get offended, Pisces.”

“I find that a difficult proposition given your last statement.”

“I’m just remembering how you used to be. And if you’ll remember, you *were* better than this, once.”

“I’m sure I have no recollection of such martial prowess.”

“Don’t be a prat. I’m not trying to—”

Ceria broke off. She turned her head.

“Ah, Ksmvr? Do you need something?”

The Antinium nodded. He was standing a few feet away from the two adventurers, making no effort to conceal his eavesdropping. He stared fixedly at Ceria and Pisces.

“I would like to stay and observe the act of chastisement so I may learn to do it myself in a command situation.”

“I’m not sure that’s such a—”

“No, no. Let the Antinium stay.”

Pisces folded his arms, looking angry. He snapped at Ceria.

“By all means, Springwalker. Say your piece.”

She took a breath. This wasn’t the time for it. But she couldn’t stop now. Calmly, she spoke, looking Pisces in the eye.

“In the battle against that fire thing, I saw you using [Flash Step], but you got caught, Pisces. When we were students together you could have danced around that construct for days without letting it get near you.”

“And?”

Ceria spread her hands.

“And that’s all. I’m just making an observation.”

“I see.”

“Don’t get offended. I’m not lecturing you, or complaining. Your quick thinking saved us, and you more than pulled your weight. We would have been dead without your help, and without your skeletons we wouldn’t have even found the tunnel. I’m just worried about what you’ve lost.”

The [Mage] considered this. He lost some of the hostility in his stance and uncrossed his arms.

“I see. Well, I am relieved to know you hold some part of me in high esteem. But I’m afraid I have no answer for you. I have simply...lost my touch as it were.”

“That’s all?”

“What do you want me to say, Springwalker? I have grown lax, it’s true. I don’t exactly duel other mages in the corridors anymore, and have little need for fencing.”

“Maybe not as a [Necromancer]. But Pisces the adventurer would be even more of an asset if he had his old skills back. I’m not saying you have to—I’m just saying that I admired that part of you.”

“I see.”

Ceria and Pisces stared at each other for a bit longer. Ksmvr stared at both of them, looking disappointed.

“Will there be no exchange of blows? No physical confrontation?”

“No.”

“I do not believe that will be necessary.”

“I see. Well then, I shall go back to work.”

After a few seconds, so did Ceria and Pisces. And after a few more minutes, they had a small pile of what might be called loot by an optimist, and a stairway made of bones.

This one was thinner, Ceria noticed as she gazed upwards. It was no less sturdy, but Pisces had clearly taxed himself creating it. The mage sat on the ground next to Yvlon as the two rested for a moment. They were exhausted. So were Ceria and Ksmvr, but they were in far better shape by comparison.

“We’ll go up, Ksmvr and I. I think the fire thing’s dead—if it’s not we’ll come running down. But we’ll haul up all this...stuff. You two just rest.”

They nodded, and Ceria seized the sword, her pack, and Pisces’ pack before climbing the stairs. Her legs felt wobbly, but she was determined not to slip or fall.

At last, Ceria reached the top. She pulled herself up over the ledge of burnt and melted stone, relieved it was no longer hot to the touch. She stood up and looked around.

“Oh...”

Everything was black and melted. The walls, the ceiling—everything had warped, and the white-hot flames had left sooty reminders where it had burned. It almost felt like Ceria was still back in the pit.

But then she looked in the treasure room, what had been the treasure room, and felt her heart break. It was completely ruined. There was nothing left of the vision she had seen upon first entering. Nothing at all.

The bookshelf had been turned to ash. The weapons had melted, at least, that was what Ceria could guess. The entire room was almost one solid color, that of charcoal black. Of a certainty, there were no magical weapons left, no books full of spells. Where the gold had been there was only a misshapen dark mass, and there was no staff.

It had been burnt away. Ceria felt her eyes sting as she gazed at the place where it had been, but she couldn’t even find the emotion to weep right now. She had wounded friends down below—there was no time for self-recriminations.

“Even so. What a waste.”

Ceria stared at the pile of burnt wood that had been the desk. Ksmvr walked into the room and poked around the destroyed bits. He paused as he kicked at a sooty mass and looked at Ceria.

“There is gold underneath the ash, Captain Ceria.”

“Gold?”

“And gemstones. They have melted into the gold.”

Ksmvr pointed as Ceria practically dashed over. She saw a huge, melted mass of what first appeared to be scorched rock. But underneath the layer of blackness was a familiar dull gleam.

“Dead gods. It *is* gold!”

The treasure she had seen in the back of the room had been consumed by the fire as well. But unlike the other materials in the room, gold was still gold no matter what shape it took. Ceria tried to prize the gold free, and found that it had become one solid mass that had stuck to the floor.

“We’ll have to dig it up. But this—”

“I assume this is a good thing.”

“Very good.”

Ceria’s heart beat faster. The gold coins she and the others had so carefully used to buy their supplies—how many coins would this lump of fused metal make? She couldn’t imagine, especially because she knew the gold coins traded across the world weren’t pure gold. This probably was.

“Let’s get Pisces and Yvlon. They have to see this.”

As they went to leave the room, Ceria found something else as her foot landed in a pile of ash. She saw a flash of brown and snatched up a small bag, drawstrings tightly fastened. Ksmvr peered at it as Ceria lifted it up.

“What the...?”

“It is a bag, Captain.”

Ceria eyed Ksmvr. He ducked his head and shut up. She stared at the small satchel and remembered it, vaguely. It had been on the desk next to the staff...

“It’s not even burnt.”

“It is clearly magical. Should we open it and see what it contains?”

It had to be a bag of holding. It probably held...Ceria’s mind spun at the implications. But her internal warning bells all went off at the thought of opening it.

“No. It might be trapped. We’ll take it with us, but no one opens it or even drops it, okay?”

“I understand. Let us find the others and convey this good news.”

“Sure.”

Ksmvr and Ceria made three trips up and down the ivory staircase, twice to haul up the burnt remains of the treasure, and then to help Yvlon

and Pisces make their way up. And after the two had gotten over their initial dismay and relief at the treasure obtained, they made a proper survey of what they'd found.

"This sword is clearly magical. I wouldn't risk using it in combat, but perhaps it could be repaired?"

Pisces murmured to the others as he lifted up the broken sword. The pommel had cracked while the actual blade looked only scorched, but that could well have been part of the spell matrices, and no one dared to separate it.

"A cracked shield. Not good. Can we still use it?"

Yvlon showed the buckler to Ceria. She nodded as she stared at the small bag and the adventurers' pack, the only two wholly unburned objects.

"It's magical too. We have to try."

"We have quite a bit of gold as well."

Ksmvr had helped lever up the metal and gems and then saw the pieces into manageable chunks. Now he was attempting to cram as many pieces as possible into their packs. Ceria eyed one bulging rucksack. She doubted *she* could carry the extremely dense gold, tired as she was. Yvlon and Pisces?

It was a hard thing to say out loud, but in one respect, their adventure wasn't over yet. Ceria didn't beat about the bush as Ksmvr awkwardly tied the weapons—sword, buckler, dagger, and another sword, of which only the blade remained—into a bundle to be carried.

"We've got to get back to a city, everyone. I know we're tired, but we've got practically no rations and we're sitting ducks out here. Yvlon's injured and her armor's gone—"

"As is my sword."

"—Pisces is out of mana, I'm nearly tapped, and Ksmvr is going to have to carry most of the treasure."

Ksmvr looked up.

"I am? Hm."

"I hate to say it, but you're the strongest of us and no one else can bear the load. Do you think you can handle it?"

She didn't want to suggest burying the treasure. It was a risky move if people got wind of their haul and decided to backtrack to find anything they'd left behind. But Ceria didn't want to overburden the Antinium either. To her surprise, Ksmvr shook his head.

“It is no problem. I can drag all that we have collected if need be. I would have simply organized the distribution of weight differently if I had known I was going to be the sole carrier.”

“Oh.”

Pisces, still looking quite gray and weary, sat up slowly, groaning with what seemed to be genuine distress for once.

“I can summon—one or two undead aides. They can help lift—”

“No.”

Yvlon interrupted Pisces. She shook her head and lifted one of the packs, stumbling slightly at the weight.

“No undead. We can carry it ourselves.”

She looked at Ceria, and the half-Elf nodded.

“You heard her. We’ll get back ourselves.”

“Where to? We’re far from all the cities.”

“But we’re nearest to...ah, Remendia I think. Once we hit the main road we can catch a ride.”

“If we don’t hit bandits.”

“Dead gods. Don’t speak like that, Pisces. Let’s just get—”

Yvlon took a few steps and stumbled. Instantly, Ksmvr and Ceria grabbed her shoulder before she could fall. The taller woman smiled gratefully at them. Pisces heaved himself up with a groan and picked up the smallest pack.

“If we must persist, let us do so with dignity. Onwards, then.”

He lurched forwards, ignoring the look the other three gave him. But he was right, and soon enough Ceria and Yvlon and Ksmvr were stumbling up, out of the tunnels, out of Albez. They had seen the dungeon and retrieved the treasure.

But none of them were smiling.

“Cold.”

Ceria gritted her teeth as she walked through the snow. Pisces sneezed; Yvlon made a face.

“How’re your arms, Yvlon?”

“Just the same as when you last asked, Ceria.”

“Sorry.”

“No—I apologize.”

“Got another spell in you, Springwalker?”

Pisces chattered as he stumbled forwards in the freezing drifts. Ceria grimaced, but made a flame in her palm, feeding it as much mana as possible. Yvlon and Pisces crowded around, warming their hands.

Somehow, after all their battles in the dungeon under Albez, the Horns of Hammerad had forgotten that it was, in fact, the middle of winter above. It had been a nasty surprise to all of them to emerge into a light snow shower, but at least it hadn't been a blizzard.

Pisces sighed as his hands grew warmer, and Yvlon grunted. She was trying to warm the metal stuck to her arms, and Ceria knew she had to be coldest since the metal lost its warmth faster than bare skin.

“Sure we're going the right way?”

“I think so. The mountains are that way—we've got to be close. Maybe it's over that incline over there?”

“Damn snow makes everything invisible. I can't even see the forests—just white.”

Yvlon grumbled, swearing out loud for one of the first times in Ceria's hearing. Pisces grunted. He glanced over his shoulder and called out.

“Ksmvr! Are you okay?”

“I am...well...thank you...Comrade Pisces.”

The puffing, slightly out-of-breath reply was at odds with the way Ksmvr diligently kept his steady, unfaltering pace. He slowly trudged forwards, dragging the bulk of their goods along the ground. The one good thing the weather had given the Horns of Hammerad was that they'd been able to make a makeshift sled for Ksmvr to drag along.

“You sure you don't need help?”

Ceria and Yvlon eyed the Antinium with some concern. He shook his head, although his voice was no less strained.

“I am...designed for heavy labor. I will not...let the team down.”

“You won't. Just let us know, okay?”

“Affirmative.”

Ksmvr walked past the others, gaining a few feet before they stopped huddling around the fire and kept walking. He didn't stop. He was like a machine, like any other member of his kind, Ceria supposed. But it was different with Ksmvr. He was working for the sake of his team, not the

other Antinium. Somehow, that made him feel that much more valuable to the others.

“Let’s keep moving.”

Ceria let the flame fade from her hands and Pisces and Yvlon dropped their arms with a sigh. All three staggered slightly before the momentum kept them going. Ahead, Ksmvr slipped on a patch of snow but regained his footing and took another step forwards.

They were all reaching the end of their physical endurance. Ceria had already passed around the hard biscuit and dried meat in their packs—the only rations they had left—and now the only thing keeping the adventurers going was the thought of food and rest.

No one was smiling. No one really talked, except for Ceria, and only then to make sure no one else was freezing. The Horns of Hammerad moved in...if not depression, something reminiscent of it.

Yes, they had found treasure in Albez, among the ruins. Yes, they had gone through traps and against all odds survived. But what had they for their trouble?

One burned spellbook, some damaged magical artifacts practically leaking magic, a backpack full of dead adventurer’s gear, and a small bag that was almost definitely trapped with magic way above their ability to dispel. Oh, and nearly eighty pounds of gold and fused gemstones.

It was a win, and it would have been cause for celebration for over a week in the old Horns of Hammerad. But in Ceria’s weary mind, there was more than a bit of regret and failure she couldn’t shake.

She remembered the glimmering staff and the personal arms and equipment of a powerful mage of the past, one capable of creating magical traps and a summoned construct that could last for hundreds or thousands of years.

“But we’re alive.”

“What was that, Ceria?”

“Nothing.”

They weren’t a proper Silver-rank team, not yet. Individually they were all better than average, but together they still had their differences. But they’d come through their first adventure, their first *dungeon* alive and in one piece.

That had to count for something. It did count.

“There’s the city.”

Pisces called out as he crested the incline. Ceria raised her head and smiled in relief.

“Remendia?”

Yvlon peered at the city and shook her head.

“Nope. Too small. We must be at Ocre.”

“Close enough. It’s got walls and a gate. That’s all I want.”

“Okay, let’s get in there.”

“Should we plan out where we go once we get in the city? In case we get separated?”

Confused, Ceria looked at Yvlon.

“What? Why?”

The woman gave Ceria a weary grin.

“We’re entering the city with a fortune in gold and treasure, Ceria. If we don’t get this stuff under guard quick, it’ll be gone before we get to the market.”

Ceria muttered a half-Elven curse word involving flowers.

“I forgot that. You’re right. Ksmvr, Pisces, we’ve got to get the treasure to the Adventurer’s Guild the instant we get through the gates.”

“Will it be safe there?”

“Should be. And if it’s not, the Adventurer’s Guild has to compensate us. Just don’t stop, don’t drop the bags—Ksmvr, spread it out so we can all carry it—and don’t promise anyone anything, okay?”

Pisces nodded as Ksmvr began dividing the treasure. He grunted as he lifted his pack, but there was a smile on his face. The Antinium nodded.

“Got it.”

“We will heed your instructions.”

“Okay.”

Ceria took a breath. She didn’t know what to say. Here they were, at the end of their quest and—well, what should she tell them? She was their Captain, even if they’d elected her in a second. But hadn’t it been that way with Calruz? He’d always made his team feel like they were a success, even after the hardest of missions. What had he said?

She couldn’t remember the words, but Ceria remembered the feeling. She called on that now, and looked the other Horns of Hammerad in the eye.

“Heads held high, everyone. It’s been a long journey, but we did it. We found treasure in Albez—probably the biggest haul in over a decade! If

that's not worth a bit of pride, I don't know what is."

She saw three pairs of eyes on her, and three people smiled. One, a young woman, grinned and grimaced in pain, but her eyes were steady. The young man with haunted eyes and an expression more used to sneering than honest emotion gave her a true smile now that reminded her of the past. And the Antinium opened his mandibles, his face foreign and to some, a face of nightmares. But he was smiling too.

Ceria pointed towards the walls of the city. The guards at the wall hadn't spotted them yet; there was a bit of foot traffic navigating the frozen road into the city, but she was sure they would stand out the moment they got close. Gold had its own glitter.

"It's going to be Humans crawling all over us when we get in, so let's stick together. If you get lost, shout and we'll be along. Don't drop anything and remember, we're adventurers. We stick together."

She led them down the hill, towards the gates. Her legs were exhausted, but Ceria put more energy into them. They were here, safe! She smiled up at the guards on the walls, never happier to see a Human in her life. She heard a shout as they spotted the armed warriors approaching—not too warily—adventurers were a common sight. She raised a hand to wave up at them, waiting for them to notice the gold—

"Antinium at the gates! We're under attack!"

"What?"

Ceria heard the panicked shout and with a shock, realized the guards were raising their bows and calling the alarm. She shouted desperately and waved at them—it was just Ksmvr! How could they not tell he was alone and with them? But then she saw the arrows at the strings and screamed.

"Ksmvr! Watch out!"

The Antinium had been waving up at the wall, copying Ceria. As soon as he saw the bows he dropped his pack and tried to take cover in the snow. He dove out of the way as a rain of arrows thudded into the ground next to him. The Antinium stood back up and staggered as an arrow sprouted from his right shoulder.

"Stop! Stop, damn you!"

Ceria *shouted* up at the wall, but no one was listening. The [Guardsmen] were preparing another volley. She saw someone run past her and then saw Yvlon. The woman threw herself in front of Ksmvr, holding the remnant of her plate armor and her pack filled with the gold. She crouched in front of

the Antinium as arrows rained down on them again. Her protection wasn't perfect, but the hail of arrows mostly bounced off her pack and armor. Ksmvr *hissed* as an arrow struck his leg and another glanced off his lower back, but he didn't move.

"Cease fire!"

This time Pisces took up the call. He raised his voice and then Ceria remembered she had magic. She touched her throat and then bellowed.

"Stop shooting you damn Humans! We're adventurers!"

Her voice bounced off the walls and she heard confused shouting. The Humans lowered their bows for a second, and then someone who looked like an officer was running, pointing at them. Ceria and Pisces ran over to Yvlon, watching the [Guardsmen] warily. No more arrows flew down from the walls, and after a second, Ceria saw people rushing down the battlements.

Yvlon crouched beside Ksmvr, still shielding him. The Antinium was trying to get up and she was holding him down.

"Don't move. They might loose another volley. Ksmvr, are you okay?"

"I am fine. Captain, permission to return fire?"

"Do you have a bow?"

"...Permission to throw things?"

"No. Just hold on."

Ceria watched as the people on the wall shouted. Then, one of them stood up and raised a flag. It was white. Pisces snorted at it.

"Is that supposed to mean they surrender? Or that they're not going to try and kill us?"

"Either one works for me. Oh look, now they've noticed the gold. They're sending a delegation."

Yvlon just sighed. She helped Ksmvr up. The Antinium grunted as he snapped the shaft of the arrow in his leg. The one in his shoulder he left alone as he hefted his pack.

"Adventurers! The [Guardsmen] are standing down! The gates are open!"

Someone was shouting from the walls. Ceria looked up and growled.

"That's all they can say?"

She raised her skeletal hand and gave the [Guardsmen] on the wall an unmistakable gesture. Then she looked around. Pisces was giving the people clustered at the gates an evil eye. Yvlon was helping Ksmvr walk

forwards, and the Antinium was dragging his pack. Everyone had the same grim expression on their face. She nodded.

“New plan. We go in and if anyone gets in our way, you have my full permission to hit them. Stick together, and until we get to the Adventurer’s Guild and log our claim, no one slows us down.”

There was indeed a group of anxious-looking people forming at the gates. Ceria scowled. Pisces rubbed at his face and spoke to no one in particular.

“I really hate this continent.”

“Humans.”

“I would like to not have this arrow in my leg.”

“Adventurer’s Guild and bed. And I will kick anyone who gets in our way.”

For once it looked like they all had something they could agree on.

What happened when adventurers came back from a dungeon? For all that the stories of adventurers returning with fame and fortune were told to every child, it was rare enough that no one had any structure to what came next.

But there was a certain rhythm to things. Assuming the adventurers were not being pursued by monsters or grievously injured—and assuming they came back successfully bearing treasure, not laden down with failure and regret—there was inevitably a lot of fuss.

It began at the walls. The [Guardsmen] on duty would always be the first to notice adventurers coming in, and there was a certain walk the triumphant had. Not to mention the glitter of gold. They would be the first to shout the news, and then it was just a matter of who was standing closest to the gates.

Everyone loved treasure. True, Drakes and Humans were known to love it most of all, but there wasn’t an adult or child who wouldn’t drop whatever they were doing and rush to see what wonders had been unearthed by the brave souls who had found some ancient tomb or lair.

Next would come the procession, as the adventurers made their way through a crowd only too willing to take their burdens off their shoulders—and run away with it. Depending on the efficiency of the local City Watch,

the streets would be kept clear for the adventurers to make their way to their Guild. In the worst case scenario, the party of weary warriors would have to fight their way through a mob, fending off [Pickpockets] and even attacks with blade and spell.

And then would come the moment they arrived at their Guild, where the doors would be thrown open and the treasure displayed and sorted, and the adventurers would be able to rest, knowing their hard-won earnings were safely stored away and guarded by spell and lock. They would then either drink until they were unconscious, eat half a roasted pig, do both, or simply fall asleep there and then.

That was the way an adventurers' return went. Events almost always transpired according to this formula, mainly because there was only a finite number of ways people bearing treasure and wealth beyond imagining were greeted. Shooting arrows at them was a first, and so the Horns of Hammerad entered the city in a rather different way than the standard.

"Move it!"

Ceria fired an [Ice Spike] spell over the heads of the first fawning delegation that came to greet them. The people screamed and ducked, which made progressing far easier. She and the other Horns of Hammerad marched through the streets, ignoring the voices that pressed around them.

"Honored adventurers, please excuse—"

"Is that an Antinium? Are they attacking?"

"You're injured! Let us help—"

There were all too many hands reaching for the gold poking out of the bags the adventurers carried. Pisces snarled as a boy reached out for his pack.

"Touch my bag child, and I will reanimate your corpse just so I can *beat it to death again*."

The boy fled, but there were many more to take his place. Yvlon shouldered people aside, face set.

"Make way! We've got wounded! Where's the Adventurer's Guild?"

Fortunately it wasn't too far down the street. Ceria ignored the crowds and the questions. She threw fire on the ground and people scattered—Pisces blew cold air at people, making them retreat. Ksmvr had his own bubble of space.

"If anyone touches me, I will be forced to defend myself with non-lethal but exceptionally painful force."

No one went near him, and through shouting, pushing, and mainly the last dregs of their strength, the Horns of Hammerad burst through the doors of the Adventurer's Guild. Men and women in armor, mages sitting at tables, a [Rogue] dicing with an [Archer], even an armored Minotaur all stopped and stared at the crowd. And then at the Horns of Hammerad.

Ceria lifted her pack, hearing the fabric ripping and praying it wouldn't give out at this last moment. She staggered towards the desk, and looked into the eyes of a startled male [Receptionist]. He gaped down at her, and at her three companions, all holding gold, magical swords—

“Hey.”

The half-Elf croaked the words out loud and then realized there was silence. Suddenly, the shouting had gone still, and she realized that everyone was looking at her. She looked up, and saw the man staring at her, transfixed. What? Was there something on her face?

Was it her burnt hair, her travel-stained garments? The fortune in gold in her pack, the way Yvlon's armor had melted onto her arms? Ksmvr, the arrows sticking out from his body? Pisces, covered in grime and dust but with magic glimmering at his fingertips? Or was it her, Ceria, a half-Elf with one skeletal hand who looked like she'd dug herself out of the ground?

“—I want...”

Ceria croaked the words in the silence. The [Receptionist], the adventurers—the people crowding around the doorway—everyone's eyes were on her. She took a breath, coughed.

“—I want a full receipt for everything we drop off. And then I want a bed in an inn, but before that my companion needs your best [Healer] and potions, immediately.”

The man just stared at her. His lip was trembling, Ceria noticed. Was he that afraid? That stunned? What should she say? But then she felt people stepping up next to her, three of them. Pisces glared at the man at the desk.

“And we want food.”

Yvlon nodded, exhausted.

“And a bed. Did you mention that, Ceria?”

Pisces pulled at his robes, vomit-stained, bloody, burnt.

“And I would like a change of clothes. A new robe.”

Ksmvr raised a hand and pointed with another hand to his shoulder.

“I would like someone to pull the arrow out of my side.”

The spell broke. The man quavered, stepped back, and stared at Ceria.

“C-certainly. We can do all that. But ah, who are you? An adventuring team no doubt?”

“Who are we?”

Ceria stared at him blankly, but then realized she hadn’t introduced herself. It was customary for any new team to do so immediately, but she’d been so used to Selys knowing them on sight she hadn’t bothered. She gestured at her teammates and herself.

“We’re the Horns of Hammerad.”

“What? I thought they—you were dead.”

The half-Elf gave the man at the desk a wide, manic grin. She laughed, coughed, and spoke softly in the silence.

“We’re not dead yet.”

What happens when the adventurers return with treasure? The real question is: how does the Adventurer’s Guild handle it? For the [Receptionists] and other staff employed at the Guilds, the moment when the weary [Warrior] walks in with a [King]’s ransom in jewels is the hardest. Things have to be immediately counted, a receipt has to be drawn up and approved by mage, guards have to be posted to prevent those with sticky fingers from walking off with everything—

Generally, [Rogues], [Thieves], and people with such classes are banned from the Guild for a good period of time. But the most important thing, every experienced desk-warrior will agree, is tending to the adventurers. In their post-battle state, they are often grumpy, irritated, and as of such, tending to their needs is the highest priority.

The [Receptionists] and other staff at the Adventurer’s Guild in Ocre might not have been high-level, but they knew that when exhausted, irritated adventurers came in with more gold than they could carry, the correct response was always ‘yes’.

In fact, the word yes should be accompanied by more honeyed phrases if possible, such as: On credit? Why certainly. We’ll have the best inn reserved, and porters are on the way. In fact, let me just open our emergency stash of potions right now...

That was how Ceria, Pisces, Yvlon, and Ksmvr found themselves in the best inn in the city in short order, clutching magically-signed receipts for

their goods while Silver-rank adventurers were hired to guard the treasure now sitting in the Guild vaults. All four were swaying, but their wounds had been healed with the best potions, they'd been given a full meal which none of them had finished from sheer exhaustion, and Yvlon had already been booked to see the best [Healer] in the city, along with a [Blacksmith].

But for now they were too exhausted to do anything but sleep. Which they did. And when they woke up and found an [Innkeeper] beaming and ready to serve them anything they wanted—including insects and spiders for Ksmvr, if the good Antinium was so inclined—they found a bit of life had come back into their world.

“Do we need to get back to the Guild right away?”

Pisces twisted in the elegant seat he was sitting in. The private room of The Nobleman's Disgrace was sumptuously adorned, and the meal in front of them had no less sumpt. Ceria pushed back her meal of steak—a real *steak*, cooked and seasoned despite the winter—patting her belly.

“I don't think we do. It's probably good to, I guess.”

“You're sure those [Receptionists] aren't leaving with our treasure as we speak? What's to stop them?”

“The fact that every [Assassin] in the continent would be hired if they did. Relax, Pisces. The Adventurer's Guild has a solemn contract with us adventurers. If we couldn't trust them with what we find, we wouldn't have anything to do with them.”

Yvlon laughed softly as she tore into soft bread seasoned with garlic. Her motions were stiff, but she had reassured the others that she had felt no pain in the morning, and she had several healing potions on her in the meanwhile.

“We should probably go soon though, because the prices for guarding what we earned won't be low.”

“True.”

Ceria made a face. She eyed the third of a steak and wondered if she could eat it. She thought about puking up what she'd eaten and pushed it over to Pisces with a sigh. He began chomping down her food. He eyed the two experienced adventurers warily.

“What kind of prices are we talking about?”

“Oh, hiring guards, identifying magical items—I'm not sure if the Guild does that, but they'll definitely overcharge us for the potions they gave us. We're oozing gold, and they'll try to squeeze us for everything they can.”

“All the more reason to leave right away. We should sell what we can and get the artifacts identified by a reputable mage. Unless there is a procedure we must go through?”

He looked at Yvlon and Ceria expectantly. Ksmvr, engrossed in eating the bread dough which he had explicitly requested from the [Chef], looked up. Ceria exchanged a glance with Yvlon and hesitated.

What *did* they do? She thought about it, and then felt something peculiar in her stomach. It felt...light. What would they have done, if she'd been here with Calruz and Gerial, celebrating after getting the treasure out of Liscor? They'd never...discussed it, but here they were, stuck.

“I don't know.”

Ceria's lips twitched a bit. She smiled.

“What?”

Pisces and Ksmvr looked at Ceria oddly. She smiled a bit wider, as a fuzzy sensation began to float upwards in her chest.

“I don't know. I've never found a magical artifact this powerful before. I've never—Yvlon, have you ever come out of a dungeon with this kind of loot?”

The other woman paused, and then adopted the same smile.

“Never. I'd never considered it. We're walking blind, aren't we? I've never seen a group come in with as much gold as we have—or with as many magical artifacts!”

“And they're broken! Just imagine—we'll have to identify them, and then see if there's an [Enchanter] strong enough to fix them! Could anyone even do that in this day and age?”

Ceria laughed, almost incredulously. Pisces and Ksmvr looked surprised, but then they found the same emotion in their chests. The mage began to grin, and so did the Antinium, in his own way.

“Those merchants out there—they're going to try and rob us blind!”

“They are!”

“I wouldn't be surprised if every [Footpad] and [Thug] in the city's memorized our faces. And the [Shopkeepers]—dead gods, we'll be lucky if we can buy a loaf of bread for a gold coin!”

Ksmvr nodded his head as the others laughed and smiled wider.

“I find the prospect of being shortchanged quite pleasant.”

The others looked at each other, laughing, and then falling into a smiling silence.

“We did it.”

“We did, didn’t we?”

“We succeeded despite all the odds. We found treasure—in ruined Albez, no less!”

“We accomplished our task with zero casualties.”

Ceria looked around the table, at the three smiling faces. She couldn’t keep hers off her face. She felt a twinge in her heart, but the smile never faded. She said the words softly, disbelievingly.

“We really did it.”

The Horns of Hammerad left the inn around midday, politely fending off the [Innkeeper] as he tried to entice them with more food, and the luxuries of his inn. They never noticed the young boy who sped out the back door the instant they were done eating, and so after they left the inn ten minutes later, they were unprepared for what came next.

Ceria put her hand on the doorknob and opened it. She walked outside, blinking at the sunlight, and was then overwhelmed by sound and motion and movement. She heard screaming, wild, frenzied, and tensed.

But it was no group of thugs that came to attack her, no mob. Ceria blinked and gaped as her eyes adjusted and she saw people, standing outside the inn and shouting and waving at her and the other Horns of Hammerad as they left their inn.

A wall of Humanity, stomping and clapping and cheering at the top of their lungs lined both sides of the street. People hung out of windows in buildings, shouting down at the Horns of Hammerad. Still more were standing on ledges or even on the rooftops, just to see.

They waved flags, threw colored flour—flowers being out of season—and waved desperately to attract the attention of the adventurers. People of the [Musician] class were playing their instruments loudly, and as the Horns of Hammerad exited the inn and stared, someone began hitting a drum and trumpets began to sound.

Ksmvr stared around wildly, confused and unsure of what to do. Yvlon was just gaping, and Pisces and Ceria were dumbstruck. The half-Elf could barely process what was occurring before her eyes. This looked like a celebration. For her? For *them*?

Everyone was staring at her. The sun was out, and it was like a sea of faces was opened up, every eye looking at her, every face in a smile or shouting at her. It was overwhelming, even terrifying—

And to Ceria, it was a complete and utter surprise. She couldn't even believe it was for her. But she took a step forwards on the cobbled street and the people went wild. They were cheering, yes, shouting—not just her name, but the name of her party!

“Horns! The Horns of Hammerad!”

“Hammerad!”

“Hammerbad!”

She'd been an adventurers for years, but Ceria had never had anyone cheer for her. Oh, a village had turned out now and then once they'd taken care of a monster threat, and maybe they'd have a round of drinks bought for them, but the old Horns of Hammerad had never warranted even a parade. And this?

Ceria lifted her hand hesitantly, and the wave of noise it provoked nearly blew her away. People were cheering and waving handkerchiefs, pointing and smiling—

At her?

She still couldn't believe it. But part of Ceria, once she had overcome the shock, part of her understood.

How long had it been since she'd been a child? When had she... forgotten what it was like to be an adventurer, what it meant to ordinary people? She was someone who went into dark places and slew monsters, who went into the depths of the darkest dungeon and came out with that which shone even brighter than the sun. She was an Adventurer, a hero in the imaginations of many. And she had conquered a dungeon, the feat that every adventurer dreams of.

She had seen the treasure, and she had come back with it. She had proven that there was truth to the old tales, and given them something to hold onto. A bit of truth in the stories. The half-Elf walked forwards, raising her hand, and they shouted and cheered and called her name.

Pisces walked behind Ceria, staring, just staring. He looked down the rows of smiling faces, and felt all that attention, that goodwill directed at him. It was an unfamiliar feeling, bewitching, more enchanting than any spell. He saw young women smiling at *him*, and children running along, staring at him. He was wearing crimson red robes, the ones loaned to him to

replace his dirty garments. But the [Mage], the [Necromancer] walked in them as if they were made for him, and when he made his fingers spark with magic, the crowd cheered and *oohed* and *aahed*, for there went a true [Mage], a master of magic.

Yvlon walked silently, in a bubble of her own. She stared at the crowd, and saw people pointing to her arms. But not in disgust. She was a wounded hero, a warrior who had survived a great battle. And her eyes found the young men and women wearing worn armor and equipment, whose eyes were on her, hopeful, dreaming of the day they might be like her. And she thought of those she had left behind, and she kept her back straight as the wind blew her golden hair behind her.

For Ksmvr, he felt as all Humans felt when they saw the Antinium and realized there was another world they had never known, another people. He looked into smiling faces, Human ones filled with emotion and life, and realized how small his understanding of the world had been.

And the Humans looked back, and saw a new kind of adventurer, no longer a nameless horror. They stared at Ksmvr with a bit of fright, but mostly awe. The Antinium waved with his three hands at the crowds, and the people cheered even at him. He might be a monstrous Antinium, but he was an adventurer too. He was special.

Ceria walked down the street, and breathed in. Slowly. The air was cold, but the city was warm, burning even. There were people around her, calling out her name, loving her though they had never seen her face before in their lives. She looked around, and saw a sight she had never even dreamed of in the sixty years she had been alive.

It was humbling, wonderful, and in her heart, Ceria felt something give. She looked over with slightly blurred eyes and saw a tall figure to her left. In her mind's eye, Gerial walked down the street, slightly stiff but nearly bursting with pride, waving a hand now and then and going red when they cheered his name.

Ahead of her, Calruz strode ahead, tall, back straight to the sky, not looking left or right as he kept up his dignified façade—but loving every minute of it.

Behind her, Sostrom twirled his staff and emitted a shower of light particles, much to the delight of those watching. Hunt and Marian waved and cheered as well, and the other Horns of Hammerad walked proudly, marching as one.

For a moment. And then Ceria was back to the present, and she saw Pisces flicking his fingers and sending pink doves flying across the crowd, making them *shriek* and reach for the apparitions of light. She saw Ksmvr catch a wilted flower and eat it, Yvlon smiled at a young boy who ran out of the crowd to stare at her arms, and then she looked ahead.

The sky was very bright. And it was still cold, still winter. But right now she felt warm. Ceria murmured the words to herself, and let them disappear in the sounds of celebration.

“What an adventure.”

And somehow, it felt like it had only just begun.

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Ryoka Griffin stood on the top of a snow-covered hill, facing the wind. Her arms were spread out, and she raised her head as the cold winter winds blew around her. The snow-flecked breeze tugged at her light clothing, a shirt and loose leggings, wholly inappropriate for the season. But the young woman paid no attention to the cold. In fact, such was her body heat that the snow had melted around her bare feet, exposing flattened grass underneath.

She was completely still as the air ruffled her long hair. Ryoka breathed in and felt the cold in her lungs. But she let not one muscle move; made no concession to the elements. Her breathing slowed, and Ryoka became one with nature. She was one with the world. One with the cosmos.

After another minute Ryoka opened her eyes.

“This is stupid.”

She dropped her arms to her side. She twisted her neck and heard a *crick*. Wincing, she rubbed at her shoulders and looked around. Then she glared at her midriff.

“Hey, Ivolethe! Did you hear me? I said this is stupid. It’s not working.”

Somewhat predictably, Ryoka’s midriff did not respond to her comment. But after a second, one of the compartments in her belt rustled, and a small head poked out. The tiny crystal head had bulging cheeks, and as Ivolethe flew out of the pouch she crammed the last bit of dried sweet fruit into her mouth.

“What’s wrong, Ryoka?”

The young woman paused and eyed Ivolethe. The naked faerie was just as ignorant of the cold as Ryoka was, but she had clearly been feasting in Ryoka’s pouch while the young woman tried to commune with the wind. The faerie was covered in bits of dried fruit; the sticky sweets clung to her like leeches.

Ivolethe didn’t seem to mind. The faerie peeled a bit of raisin off her stomach while Ryoka pushed at her hair distractedly. She spoke with waspish exasperation, but trying to moderate her tone.

“This isn’t working. I’ve been here for over an hour doing what you said, and all I have to show for it is wet feet and sore shoulders.”

“Hmm.”

The faerie eyed Ryoka skeptically, and then flew around her in a quick pattern. When she stopped she looked disappointed.

“You feel nothing? Even after taking in the wind?”

“Aside from the need to pee? Nothing.”

Ryoka sighed as the faerie scowled. She spread her hands.

“I don’t know. What *should* I be feeling?”

“The wind.”

The faerie gave her a look as if Ryoka was insane. Ryoka gave the faerie the same look.

“I’ve been feeling the wind. But I don’t feel a connection to it or whatever. Look, is there something else we can try?”

“I suppose we must try something else, then.”

Ivolethe screwed up her face in concentration. Ryoka began stretching her sore legs, watching the faerie think.

In theory, they were right now studying faerie magic. That was to say, Ivolethe was trying to teach Ryoka how the Frost Faeries conjured snow and moved faster than anything Ryoka had even seen in the world. Trying was the operative word here, though.

“Are you sure this is how you teach people faerie magic?”

“No.”

Ryoka paused as she grabbed her foot from behind, stretching the muscles in her legs out.

“What do you mean, ‘no’? I thought you knew what you were doing! You told me to stand here and listen to the wind!”

The faerie glared at her.

“And I thought it would help! No wonder ye heard nothing, though, since all ye do is jabber on with your complaints!”

“I’m doing my best. But I don’t even know what I’m doing! What part of the wind are you talking about?”

“There!”

Ryoka’s head turned as the faerie shouted. All she saw was a bit of grey sky. She turned back to the faerie, scowling. But Ivolethe didn’t look like she was pulling a prank on Ryoka. She flew up swiftly into the sky, over a hundred feet in seconds, and then flew in a twisting, downwards spiral around the hill. The human girl watched her, entranced by the graceful motion.

The faerie flew past Ryoka in a rush of air, and then stopped. She looked down at Ryoka, smiling. Ryoka had to smile back.

“Did ye see it?”

Ryoka paused and frowned.

“See what?”

Ivolethe’s smile faded and her face went slack. She gestured.

“The wind, of course! Did ye see as I followed it?”

“I saw you flying. That’s all.”

The tiny faerie slapped her forehead and shouted curses at Ryoka. The Runner listened, slightly impressed at the variety of insults.

“Look, clearly I can’t see what you can. You might be seeing something by magic or with your sense that I can’t. Can you try showing me whatever’s so important another way?”

Ivolethe grumbled and folded her arms as she thought.

“Perhaps. But this is the most obvious way for me.”

“Really?”

Another scowl.

“It is not as if I have practice teaching magic to mortals. The fey come into existence knowing magic. Teaching you magic is like trying to teach a fish to swim.”

Ryoka opened her mouth to reply and paused. She frowned, raised a finger.

“What do you—”

Ivolethe rolled her eyes, annoyed.

“No one *teaches* a fish to swim, fool! They either know or they do not.”

“Ah, right. Well, try thinking like a bird, then. Show me how a fish would teach a bird to swim or something. I don’t feel anything so far.”

A glare was the only warning Ryoka got. Ivolethe flew up, and then the wind changed. Ryoka felt *that*, and she saw a wall of white snow swirl upwards and then rush at her like a wave.

“*Holy—*”

The gust of wind and snow blew Ryoka off the hilltop. She tumbled down the slope, cursing and shouting. When she sat up, dizzy and bruised, Ivolethe flew down and grinned at her.

“Did ye feel anything?”

“*Fuck you!*”

Ryoka threw a snowball at Ivolethe. The faerie laughed and flew out of the way. She conjured a snowball of her own and Ryoka raised her arm before it collided with her bare skin. The Human and faerie continued in this vein for several minutes. In the end, Ryoka stopped because she hadn’t managed to tag Ivolethe once, and she’d taken six snowballs to the head.

“I’m tired. And the magic soup is wearing off. Let’s go back into the city and try again later, okay?”

“Okay.”

The two began to move, Ryoka starting at a jog and moving faster, Ivolethe flying high overhead, laughing in the cold. And though she'd made no progress, Ryoka felt better. She looked at the faerie flying high above her and smiled.

It's an odd thing. A precious thing. Friendship, I mean. I feel like every second I'm going to make a horrible mistake and ruin things forever. But I don't. Instead, it feels like every time I'm about to get into a fight or say something I regret I find a better word to say, or a better way to act.

I didn't lose my temper with Ivolethe. Okay, I shouted and threw snow, but that was because I knew she wouldn't care and I wouldn't hit her. She isn't like Erin. I can tell her exactly how I feel because she'll do the same for me.

It's so odd. Is Ivolethe a friend? Erin's one, I'm pretty sure of that. But can I be friends with a faerie after only two days? It feels like it, but I'm not sure.

And how would I know? I've never had a good friend before. I've had 'friends', but that's just a word. But someone who's there for you even if it means risking their life? That's new. And Ivolethe is about as good an example of that kind of friendship as you can get. She's fearless, brave, and she's quite open about the fact that she's breaking rules to hang out with me.

Because that's the nature of Frost Faeries. They're the type of beings that go all-in with whatever they do. If they want to do something, they just go for it. And I like that about them the most.

Ivolethe and I return to the city in good time. I really only left it to practice her faerie magic, and since that was a bust we get back before it's even midday. The stream of people leaving and entering Celum is still busy, but I make good time.

For two reasons. The first is that I'm a Runner, and I can essentially ignore most of the lengthy customs process the [Guardsmen] subject visitors to. The second is that I have a Frost Faerie sitting on my head, and news from yesterday has already gotten around.

It's a strange thing. If I were in the United States and I walked around with a dangerous creature like a Frost Faerie, I'd probably be tossed in jail

in a heartbeat. But in this world, I'm just treated like a high-level [Mage], or any Gold-rank adventurer, really. If Ivolethe causes trouble I'll be held accountable. Aside from that, I'm free to do whatever I want, and people give me a wide berth as an added bonus.

The Runner's Guild being destroyed would normally get me locked up and fined, but thanks to eyewitnesses seeing Persua and the other Runners grabbing Ivolethe, I got off scot-free. That may also have had to do with the fact that the Frost Faeries were busy raining ten kinds of hell on the Runners as they ran indoors, and the local Watch didn't want to paint a target on their heads.

"Where are ye going?"

Ivolethe's voice is small, but perfectly audible in my ears, even above the voices of the pedestrians shouting and clogging the streets. I run past them, finding less-crowded streets to turn down.

"I'm going to visit Erin. Then I'll see if I can find Garia. I need to thank her for yesterday."

"The big girl with the heart of a mouse? Sounds boring."

The faerie jumps off my head and flies into my pouch even as I dodge around a laborer lugging a sack of something along. She's so nimble! I can feel her rummaging around in there, and make a mental note to buy some more stuff for her to eat. I've got the coin, and it shuts her up and keeps her happy.

Here's how it stands. Since yesterday, Ivolethe has pretty much been by my side day and night. She says it's interesting and I won't complain. She sometimes leaves, when I sleep for example, but other times she seems perfectly content to stay in my belt pouch. Especially when we're indoors. I tried to convince her to leave, but she bit my thumb once. She's agreed to stay in the pouch if I'm indoors, though, and a steady supply of food means she won't break that promise.

I slow as I pass by the Runner's Guild on my way to Octavia's shop. A crowd of people, as well as a group of sweaty men holding shovels and pickaxes is gathered around the ruined building. The men are trying to

excavate the building one shovelful of snow at a time, and not having much luck.

Some of the people watching this catch sight of me. I speed up as one of the [Receptionists] gives me a dirty look. Oops. I'd better not rub salt in the wounds. At least Persua's not there—I heard she was being kept by the [Healer] for rest overnight, even though potions mended most of the wounds I gave her.

Persua.

I shake my head and continue onwards. So many problems, and I don't have time to dwell on that. Erin comes first.

Octavia's shop is as chaotic as ever, but I immediately notice Erin's presence as soon as I push the door open. Ivolethe pokes her head out of my pouch; she feels safe enough to do that here.

“Something smells good. Is the innkeeper girl making more food?”

“Looks like it.”

I walk into the shop and hear voices arguing with each other.

“I told you—no, look at that! You've ruined it with the potion!”

“It doesn't look that bad! Stop complaining—I told you Ryoka will pay for the potions, and I want to see if it does anything!”

“I'll waste gold, that's what will happen! And—can you smell that? It's burning!”

Cautiously—I've seen how Erin experiments by now—I edge into what should be Octavia's kitchen. Instead, it's been transformed into a second alchemical workplace, and two girls are bickering over a stew that's mostly green with something bobbing in the thin liquid. I clear my throat.

“Erin? Octavia? Everything going okay?”

“No!”

They've got good synchronization. I raise my hands as Octavia tries to complain about Erin using her potions in her cooking, and Erin offers me a taste of whatever vileness is cooking away.

“I'm not here to eat anything. I just need more of that Corusdeer soup, Erin. It's wearing off again.”

“Really?”

Erin frowns and goes over to an open cupboard. It’s stocked with a half dozen jars of thick orange soup. Octavia rolls her eyes and calls after Erin.

“I *told* you that the soup was too thin this time! Too much carrot; not enough pepper!”

“It was worth a shot! Here you are Ryoka.”

“Thanks.”

I eye the mixture in the pot.

“Do I want to know?”

“I think this one’s a dud too. But we’re getting close; I can feel it! I’ve already figured out how to make mana soup!”

The girl with stitches folds her arms and snorts.

“That’s just a mana potion that’s slightly more edible than the rest. What’s the point?”

“It tastes better than your stupid potion!”

As the two begin to bicker, I edge out of the store. Erin seems...happy. At least, happy to keep doing this. I wonder why? I’m willing to foot the bill for her project, but I’d go nuts if I had to keep making failed potions all day. Or if I had to listen to Octavia for more than ten minutes straight.

“Got your magic drink?”

Ivolethe pokes her head out of my belt pouch, staring at the orange drink. I look at it as well; it’s just soup, but I feel like I’m holding a potion in some kind of videogame. Even long after it’s been bottled, the Corusdeer soup is warm to the touch; it’s magical, and if Erin can make anything else like it, I’ll shove gold down Octavia’s throat as long as it takes.

“Soup. And yes, I’m good. Let’s go find—”

“Is that you, Ryoka?”

Someone calls out to me as I leave Octavia’s shop. I whirl in surprise, and then smile.

“Fals?”

The tall Runner steps out from the wall he was leaning against. I walk towards him, smiling. Why am I so happy to see him? Maybe it’s because it feels like forever since we last spoke.

“What are you doing here?”

“Thought I’d find you; someone told me you were hanging out here every day. How have you been?”

“Good. I—good.”

I hold out a hand to shake his, and then pause. Fals looks down and sees my two missing fingers from my right hand. His face freezes—and then he clasps my hand gently as if nothing’s the matter.

“Bad run?”

“Yes.”

It’s strange how I don’t have to explain it to him. Fals nods at me, face growing serious.

“I’d wondered where you went. I heard you were at Liscor from Valceif when he came back this way—then nothing. Did you finish the delivery?”

“I did. Traded two fingers for it.”

“But you did it. A good Runner never falters, and I’ve never seen you even hesitate.”

The compliment makes me feel better, even though I didn’t know I’d been feeling bad. I nod at him, and he smiles slightly in return.

It’s so strange. The last time we spoke I still hated everything about him. But now we’re—okay. I look closer at Fals and see that he’s changed a bit as well. He looks tired, and maybe not as happy as before.

“How have you been? Are you here on a delivery?”

“I was. Had to drag over a freshly-made sword for some Silver-rank adventurer in the city. It was a pain to track her down, but it was good coin. I was going to stop by the Guild, but apparently you had something to do with it being closed?”

I blush.

“Oh. That—”

“Don’t worry about it. One of the Guild workers filled me in.”

Fals shivers a bit as the wind blows harder. He stares at my t-shirt and bare feet.

“Dead gods, you’re making me cold just looking at you. Is that part of your friendship with the…Winter Sprites?”

“This? No, this is a potion.”

“Oh.”

I feel Ivolethe rustling around in my pouch. She’s paying more attention now that Fals is talking about her.

“Are they going to press charges after all, do you think?”

Fals shook his head.

“No; everyone knows how stupid it is to mess with the Winter Sprites. Besides, ah, there’s some concern about what would happen if they did charge you. At the moment you’re banned from the guild in Celum, which isn’t saying much.”

“Huh.”

I feel the pouch at my belt open. Fals blinks as Ivolethe flies up. She lands on my head, grinning at me and him.

“Who’s the shivering mortal, Ryoka? A lover of yours? Or just a prat?”

“Shut it, Ivolethe.”

“Ivolethe? Is that the Frost Faerie?”

Fals squints at a point just to the left of my head. I’m intrigued—even when she’s sitting, Ivolethe’s glamor works.

“Yup.”

“All I see is a blur.”

Gingerly, Fals nods his head towards Ivolethe, staring to the right of her.

“I’m pleased to meet you, Miss Ivolethe.”

“Hah! A mortal with manners! Too bad ye can’t hear me, eh?”

Ivolethe laughs and flicks a bit of snow at Fals. He splutters and wipes away the snow with a grin.

“Not fond of anyone but you, are they?”

“Sorry about that.”

I flick Ivolethe off my head, making her shout in outrage. She hits me on the head with an icy pebble before retreating into my pouch. I grimace as Fals chuckles. He stops when I glare at him.

“You seem like you get along with her. I wish I could hear what she says—I assume she speaks?”

I nod.

“If we go indoors you’ll be able to see and hear her. And believe me, you’ll wish you couldn’t.”

“Well, as much as I’d like to, that’s dangerous for her, isn’t it?”

Too dangerous, especially for an immortal. I can’t believe Ivolethe would take the risk, but again, she goes all in. Death might matter to her,

but she'd risk it for a friend without a second thought.

Fals notices my expression and grows serious again. He clears his throat as he shifts his weight from one leg to another.

"I'm sorry about Persua, Ryoka. I'm not saying thrashing her was the right thing to do, but I know what she can be like."

"Yeah...I was surprised not to see you there, though. It looked like she was having a party; were you busy?"

He shakes his head, making a face.

"Hardly. I've been staying away from Celum on purpose. Ever since she got the [Double Step] Skill she's been taking away the jobs from all us City Runners. We can barely find any work. I tried talking to her, but—she wouldn't listen."

That's surprising. I frown at Fals.

"Not even to you?"

"Not to me or anyone else. It's funny, but you were right, Ryoka. Persua used to be part of the team, and we'd help her and she'd help us if we needed a hand on a tough delivery or someone got injured. But the instant she was better than the rest of us? She left us behind."

His expression is—unhappy. Fals shakes his head and stares at his worn shoes, looking more worn and upset than I've ever seen him. I stare at him, not sure what to say.

Part of me wants to mock him, to ask him what he expected. But I don't. Fals is a good Runner, and he believed in working together. That Persua threw him and every one of her friends under the bus the instant she rose above them doesn't surprise me.

What does surprise me is how quickly Fals was replaced in the Guild's hierarchy. He's the most senior Runner, and up until me and Persua, he was the best in the local area. Does that mean nothing to them?

What should I say? I think for a second, and then jerk my head.

"Come on, let's get a drink."

He's surprised, but accepts after a moment. I lead Fals at a quick jog down the street. Another good thing. Runners don't walk if we have a choice, so we get to the Frenzied Hare in a third as much time as it would take if Erin and I went*.

*Especially because she'll stop and talk to everyone she knows. Oh, hey Wesle! How's being a guard? Hey Agnes! Out for a stroll? Hey Mr. Dog! Why don't I stop for *five minutes* and scratch you between the ears!

Agnes recognizes me on sight, and in a moment she has one of the barmaids find me and Fals a table. I order a mild ale and he chooses a 'Firebird', which is some kind of a local drink. It's quite a bit stronger than my drink, which makes my eyebrows shoot up.

"You're not planning on running today?"

"I don't fancy going to another city for requests, and the Guild here is all messed up."

Fals shakes his head as he downs half of the fiery drink served to him and drinks from a glass of water quickly. He shakes his head as I sip my drink.

"Not having a good day?"

"Try week and a half. Ever since Persua got her Skill."

"Huh. I'd have thought you'd be glad to be rid of her, even if she did abandon everyone here."

"I suppose that's the one upside. She'll be running cross-continent deliveries if she makes Courier, and even if she doesn't, she'll probably move up north where there's more work."

Fals sighs as he sips at his drink again. His face is a bit red, but he still looks...morose. Yes, that's the word for it. He looks morose, beaten down, depressed. After a few more minutes, he tells me why.

"It's just a bit frustrating. I've been running and leveling up as a [Runner] for the last...must be sixteen years already. I was the best in the area until you showed up, but you trained to be as fast as you are, so I don't mind. All my Skills are stamina-based and defensive, anyways. But Persua gets lucky one time and suddenly she's a better Runner than I am."

"Isn't that the way the system works?"

"Yes. No. There's always chance in how the Skills get assigned, but there's a pattern to things! You put in the hard work, you get more Skills. But sometimes people can just get—lucky! And it's not *fair*, damn it!"

He waves for another drink, jaw set. I feel for him; he's going through what I felt not too long ago. What I struggle with now, to be honest. It just bites him harder, because he's in the system and still not getting rewarded.

"I'd say relax. Don't worry about it. Soon Persua will be gone, and you'll be the best Runner again. Well, aside from me. The Guild will be fawning all over you soon enough."

Fals stares at me and then laughs.

“It’s odd hearing *you* be the voice of reason. But you’re right. It’s just depressing seeing Persua of all people become so successful. If it was someone like Garia, I’d be cheering her on. I wish it had been her, to be honest. She could use the help.”

I frown over my drink. It’s not even half empty and Fals is on his second tumbler. He’s really upset. I guess I can listen; I was going to find Garia anyway, and she might be in here later.

“What’s wrong with Garia? Is she hurt? Or is it something else?”

“She’s had problems of her own. Garia’s a good Runner, Ryoka, you know that. She can haul as much as a horse around, but she’s slow. And sometimes—she gets lost.”

The young man in front of me shakes his head, shoulders sagging. His words make me sit up in my chair.

“Lost? What do you mean?”

He waves towards the window. Ivolethe rustles around in my pouch and I order a bowl of nuts to dump in there to keep her calm.

“It’s the snow. Everything looks the same to her—she loses track of the road. Her eyesight isn’t as good as yours or mine, that’s the problem.”

Eyesight problems? Why would—oh. They don’t have glasses here. Or do they?

“Isn’t there a—a spell that could help her out with that? Improve her vision?”

“Oh, it’s not a matter of how far she can see.”

Fals flicks his wrist dismissively.

“If it were, there are spectacles—although it would be hard for her to wear those clumsy things while running—or she could buy an enchanted pair. Pricey, but she could save up. Her problem is that she can’t tell the difference between white and grey, you see? If she’s on the road and it’s just snowed—”

Color blindness. Oh. I close my eyes. There’s nothing I can do about that. Fals nods wearily.

“Everyone’s got problems, Ryoka. Garia’s a good Runner, but winter is tough for her.”

“Sounds like it.”

I sigh. I haven’t been a good friend—a friend at all to these people, have I?

“I should hang out with her more. Talk to her. I know she’s wanted to go on a delivery with me; I could do that now and then.”

Fals smiles.

“Would you? She’d love that. In fact, she’s invited me over to stay at her parent’s farm—thanks for helping her out after she got injured. I’d go, but...it would be better if two of us went rather than just me.”

He pauses delicately and I consider the invitation. He’s saying he doesn’t like Garia, which is fair enough, I guess. It’s not as if he has to like her, and he’s still a good friend to her. And as for me?

“Why the hell not? I’ll tag along sometime. Can I bring a friend?”

“Interesting way of putting it. I’m sure Garia wouldn’t mind the company, and she tells me her folks are just as friendly as she is. I’ll ask her about it when I see her.”

“She might come walking in here soon enough. She usually eats here—more often now that there’s a new cook. Were you waiting for her?”

“What? No, I was going to see you.”

“What for?”

Fals pauses, cup touching his mouth. He lowers it and smacks his head.

“What? Oh, of course! Dead gods, I’ll start forgetting my own name soon enough.”

He puts down his drink and leans across the table to me, smiling. Suddenly I remember that Fals doesn’t like Garia. He likes *me*. At least, I think he did at one point. Fuck. What’s he going to—

“You know those adventurers you were hanging out with? The ah, Horns?”

My thoughts freeze. I focus on Fals.

“Yes. What about them?”

“I was just in Remendia, and I heard of a big celebration that was thrown in Ocre. I missed the festivities—but apparently the city was celebrating a group of adventurers who just completed a dungeon crawl. They came out with a lot of loot. And guess what they were calling themselves?”

I sit back in my chair, too shocked for words. The Horns of Hammerad? Gerial, Calruz, and—

No, no. They’re dead. It’s just Ceria now. I remember that Erin told me she’d formed another group with Pisces, Yvlon, and one of the Antinium. But I didn’t realize—

I'm standing before I know it. Fals looks at me, concerned. I stare towards the door. Ocre? Not too far. It's only midday—not even that. I can make it by tonight.

“I—I’ve got to go. I have to—can you tell Garia? And Erin?”

I look at Fals. He nods at me, understanding.

“I’ll let Garia know. But who’s Erin?”

“She’s the other innkeeper here!”

I shout at him as I run out the door. I’m already picking up the pace as I run down the street.

It’s too late now. They went through the dungeon and survived. Fals said that. It’s all over now; why am I running? But I have to see.

The last time I left them, they were all dead when I got back. All dead. I never said goodbye. But this—

They did it. I just have to see that. I have to look Ceria in the eye and congratulate her. I—

They really did it. I’m smiling, but my eyes are stinging as I race out of Celum and run through the snow.

The young woman ran through the snow, dashing through snow banks, feet flashing across the ground. She ran fast. Well, comparably fast. To the faeries flying high overhead, she was as slow as a falling snowflake.

Oh, if pressed the faeries would admit that Ryoka ran faster than the snow in a literal sense. But to their eyes she was like a rolling stone, or a scurrying rodent, or the slow orbit of the sun. She moved, yes, but she ran against the wind, blundering through nature. She did not dance upon the world like they did.

And the faeries did dance, or fly, or maybe both at the same time high overhead. Ryoka ran on, not hearing as they flew and argued with one of their number.

“Why are you following her? She’s done naught interesting for *days*, sister!”

One of the faeries complained to a faerie who flew closer to Ryoka than the rest. She sounded aggrieved, but the faerie in question—Ivolethe—just

flicked her wings at her sister as she flew.

“Ah, buzz off if you feel like it! What I do is my own concern!”

“It’s ours if you want to give away our secrets!”

Another faerie called out, voice high and challenging. She was younger than Ivolethe—ancient by mortal standards, but younger in a way only the faeries would count. She flinched as Ivolethe glared at her.

“‘Tis my business! Interfere and I’ll pluck out your eyes you stripling whelp!”

She flew aggressively at the other faerie and the young one flew away, squeaking. But other faeries flew around Ivolethe, and they were not afraid.

“It is our business, sister. You pay too much attention to her.”

“I have cause.”

“An ‘if’ on the sea of possibilities is not enough. You risk too much—death, even!—for a mortal. It is not as if she is prophesied.”

“My life is my own. Or are ye a king of mine, to order me about?”

“Not I. But what if I was to tell *our* king of what ye do? What then?”

“Yes! Stop following the mortal like a silly *pet*! You stay in her belongings like a kept thing! Stop!”

More voices urged Ivolethe. She snarled and flew at them, but the faeries just flew around her, shouting.

“Yes, come away!”

“We’ll tell!”

“You went into the place of iron! Fool!”

“It was my choice! My risk! And ye hardly helped!”

Ivolethe roared at them, her voice lost to Ryoka as the girl leapt over a frozen log below. She pointed at the other faeries, accusing.

“What was that tripe ye brought to revenge me? Destroying a building? Throwing snow and ice at those fools? ‘Twas hardly an hour passed before

you forswore vengeance and flew off as if naught had happened!”

One of the faeries laughed at Ivolethe’s anger.

“*You* went into the home of iron uninvited. *You* dared them and struck first. If you had died, we would have called for vengeance. But you are alive and only your pride is injured, so be content with that! And because of you, the mortal has a dire oath sworn against her, a prophecy of vengeance and blood!”

“I know.”

Ivolethe sighed. The faeries grew silent then; they respected oaths and vows of vengeance more than they did lives. After a while, the other faeries began to fly off. The ones around Ivolethe urged her to join them, but she just shook her head.

“A little longer. A little longer. What is time to we?”

“Careful, sister. Do not wait too long.”

“Teach her if you will! But there will be consequence and dire reckoning!”

“Aye.”

Ivolethe nodded, watching her sisters fly off. She flew lower, and whispered the words.

“There always is. But it will come no matter what I do or do not.”

Then she flew next to Ryoka and had fun creating patches of ice to trip the girl up.

Ceria Springwalker was not a half-Elf for whom socializing came to naturally. She could not be a social butterfly, or social squirrel, or social anything, really. She had friends, and she could enjoy a night at a bar or one of the parties in Wistram easily enough, but she’d grown up solitary, and gotten used to being alone once she’d left her home.

Most half-Elves were like that. And so while Ceria was perfectly content to have people fawn over her and buy her drinks (or have her buy the bar a round of drinks), she eventually had to retire from the crowds and go to her room in the inn.

Below, she could hear the party still going on. Pisces and Ksmvr were busy entertaining the mass of people crowding the tables below, and she knew they had to be drinking heavily even now. Pisces could put away a surprising amount of liquor despite his thin frame, and Ksmvr seemed to be almost immune to the stuff.

The world swam in a not-unpleasant way as Ceria lay on her bed and grinned. Some people would say that drinking before the sun had even set—in the winter, no less—was unacceptable. But those people hadn't just cleared an ancient dungeon and come back with treasure, now had they?

It had probably been a bad idea to drink the last two...three mugs, though. Ceria was just contemplating a nap when she heard a commotion on the stairs. She sat up warily, and her eyes flicked to the door. She had no gold on her—rather, she and the other Horns of Hammerad had a letter of accreditation magically sealed, allowing her to draw the coin she needed from the Merchant's Guild if need be. It was useless to thieves, but they didn't know that and already twice the bouncers at the inn had caught people trying to break into their rooms.

Were they now going for a more direct assault? Ceria focused on the [Ice Spike] spell although she really didn't want to kill anyone. Maybe a blunted [Ice Shard] spell? Or just set their clothes on fire? She heard someone shouting, and then pounding feet. She raised her hand—

And Ryoka burst into the room. The young woman's hair was a mess, and she was breathing heavily. Sweat ran down her forehead, despite her light attire. Her eyes fixed on Ceria, and the two young women stared at each other.

“Ryoka?”

Ceria stood up slowly. She heard someone shout, and then Ryoka was tackled from the side. Ceria ran out and shouted at the men trying to wrestle Ryoka. She heard faint shouting, as if someone tiny and far away was trapped in Ryoka's belt. It was almost like a buzz. But Ceria had no time to wonder what that was.

“Stop, *stop*! She's a friend!”

She shouted at the inn's security and eventually managed to get them off Ryoka. Ceria pulled the Runner up, surprised at how warm Ryoka felt. Then she managed to soothe the [Innkeeper], and got Ryoka into her room before she could start any more trouble.

"Bring up a tray of drinks, please. Something strong to take the chill off."

Ceria closed the door and pulled a seat out for Ryoka. The taller Human girl sat, looking around. The room Ceria had been given was huge, the biggest in the inn, meant for a couple. She was alone in it, befitting of her role as the team's leader. In truth, it was too big for Ceria but they weren't planning on staying in the city for more than another night, and it was perfect for talking with Ryoka.

That was, if either of them could speak. At first Ceria was buzzing with questions—how had Ryoka heard they were here? How was Erin doing? Had she heard about the Goblin attack? What about Rags? But then she found herself tongue-tied, unable to say a word.

When had they last sat together in a room, the two of them? In the inn with the Winter Sprites, so briefly. And before that? So long ago...it had been the day they'd left Esthelm, the day Ryoka had unwisely picked a fight and the Horns of Hammerad and the other adventuring groups had gone to Liscor. So long ago. A lifetime ago.

Ryoka was thinking the same thing. She sat, looking Ceria up and down. Ceria saw her eyes linger on her skeletal hand and smiled just for a second. That had to be—

"Your fingers."

The words slipped out of Ceria in a gasp. She stared at Ryoka's right hand, at the two healed stumps of scar tissue where her fingers should have been. Ryoka started, and held up her hand. She smiled, almost ruefully.

"I keep forgetting how many people haven't seen this. Yeah, I lost my fingers."

"How? Where? Was it on your delivery?"

"Yeah. The one south. It went...south."

Ryoka laughed a bit while Ceria stared at her hand. She looked away, but then deliberately held her hand out to Ceria.

"It's not exactly as bad as your hand, although I wish I'd kept the bones."

Ceria gently reached out and touched Ryoka's hand. She didn't know what to say. Losing fingers was normal for adventurers—it was all too easy to lose body parts when a monster was in your face. But it was never easy, not with a friend—

“I'm sorry.”

“It happened. There was nothing I could do to stop it.”

“A monster did it?”

“Goblin. Bit them right off.”

“Goblins—you mean, the ones that attacked Esthelm?”

“Sort of. It's a long story.”

Ryoka's expression closed off a bit. She looked pained, older. Ceria saw her shake her head.

“I'll tell you later. I'm not here to dwell on my mistakes—and I've got a lot. I just had to come here, to see you.”

“You certainly did it dramatically. Couldn't you have asked to see me rather than run up the stairs?”

The young woman grinned and shrugged, abashed.

“You're a celebrity now. They were turning away everyone who wanted to talk to you. I don't think they would have accepted my word that we were friends.”

“True.”

Ceria laughed, and the hardest part was over. She looked at Ryoka, marveling.

“Not a day's passed since we got out of Albez, and you find us. How?”

“A friend of mine heard a rumor about some Silver-rank team that cleared a dungeon. I raced over here, and every person on the street knew where you were staying.”

“Oh? So you know what we've been up to?”

“A bit. Just the important details. Although to hear other people say it, you guys went into the Ruins of Albez and slaughtered every monster you saw until you found a treasure vault.”

Ryoka grinned at Ceria. The half-Elf had to laugh.

“Hardly. We were digging around in that place aimlessly for over a week! If it weren't for the map Olesm found—dead gods, there's so much that has happened! Did you see Pisces and Ksmvr in the common room?”

“I did. They didn't recognize me, though. Of course, they were both drunk.”

“Even Ksmvr? I might have to go down and see that.”

“He’s still drinking. I’m not sure if the Antinium can get alcohol poisoning, but you might need to stop him.”

“They’ve got antidotes for that. I’ll go down in a bit. For now—”

There was a polite knock at the door. Ceria broke off and got up. The [Innkeeper] himself was at the door with some drinks for her and Ryoka. She took it and thanked him before sitting with Ryoka at the table again. The young woman shook her head as she eyed the stiff beverage.

“They treat you like royalty, don’t they?”

“Anything for the heroic adventurers. I haven’t felt this pampered—ever.”

Ceria sighed as she stared at her drink. She should have ordered water, not more alcohol. She paused, and looked at Ryoka. The other girl was staring at her.

“What?”

“Nothing. It’s just—you guys really did it, didn’t you?”

She looked at Ceria, something in her eyes. Ceria Springwalker shook her head, smiling, feeling something in her heart move.

“It wasn’t nearly as easy as the rumors make it out to be. We nearly died several times. Yvlon is getting bits of metal cut out of her arm as we speak. We’re not even sure if we can remove the armor without damaging her arm...”

“But you did it.”

“Yes. We did.”

How she wished. How she wished she could have said that to Ryoka at another time, in another place. In an inn in Liscor, laughing with delight as the other adventurers celebrated down below. But that moment would never come.

And yet, she knew that Ryoka was thinking the same thing. Seized by a sudden impulse, Ceria grabbed her mug. She lifted it.

“To the old Horns of Hammerad. We did it.”

“You did.”

The two clinked mugs and then drank. Ceria gulped the strong alcohol down and then sighed.

“It doesn’t feel real. I keep pinching myself, and I still can’t believe we’re alive.”

“You’re telling me? I just heard about all this, and I’m still in shock.”

Ceria laughed lightly.

“Well, we’ve had a day. I just keep thinking I’m going to wake up in the pit again or—”

She paused, and ignored Ryoka’s inquiring look.

“Anyways, the rumors are partly true. We’re rich, we’re famous, and we got out of Albez with a load of treasure and some magical artifacts. Pisces and Ksmvr are trying to get rid of it all today, but we’re set for a long time.”

“I’m glad.”

That was all Ryoka said, but Ceria heard everything she meant in it. She nodded, and then remembered.

“I’ve got money for Erin too—we talked, and there’s forty gold coins waiting for her.”

Ryoka whistled softly.

“That’s a lot more than she said she lent you.”

Ceria grinned.

“We’d give her even more, but we don’t have that much gold to toss around.”

“The rumor I heard coming into the city was that you and the others were set up for life.”

The half-Elf had to laugh at that, ruefully.

“We were. We pulled in nearly a hundred *pounds* worth of gold and gems, did you know? That would be enough to outfit us in style or pay for our retirement—Pisces, Yvlon and Ksmvr’s, at least, I’d run out before I died of old age—but we spent it instead.”

“On what? Magical equipment?”

“No. It’s going to the people who died in Liscor.”

“Oh.”

Silence descended again, but not for too long. Ceria explained.

“We’re giving them each a share. If we can, that is. Direct family—lovers—it’s hard to confirm, but we’ll give all the relatives of the dead what we can. It’s not enough, but it’s something.”

Ryoka nodded.

“Noble of you. Not sure it’s practical.”

“Neither am I. But Yvlon’s said she’ll forfeit her share of the magical artifacts if need be. I’m not sure it’ll come to that, but she’ll have last pick at any rate.”

“Artifacts? You mentioned those. You came away with more than just gold and jewels?”

“In a sense.”

Ceria grimaced as she explained what they’d recovered.

“Burnt and mangled, mostly. But they’re powerful. The trouble is, we can’t figure out what they do or if they’re still dangerous.”

“I can see that’s a problem. Can’t you hire another [Mage] to analyze the stuff, though?”

Ceria shook her head.

“Not in this city. There’s no one high-level enough to tell us what the items do, or whether they can be repaired. Pisces and I have had a look at the enchantments, but the more complex a spell is, the harder it is to... untangle the individual spells I guess is the best way of putting it. And since they’re all damaged, it’s even more of a mess.”

“I see.”

Ryoka frowned.

“Magical weapons, huh?”

“And a bag and the pack of a dead adventurer. Frankly, I suspect those two might be the more valuable pieces of loot. I’m sure the bag is actually a bag of holding, and if that’s the case, who knows what could be in there?”

“But you haven’t opened it?”

“Too risky. The bag and the pack are both trapped, at least, so we think. There’s a binding spell that prevents both from being opened—or damaged—and I don’t want to mess with either one. If the wards are anything like the dungeon we just went through, I wouldn’t want the bag opened even if I were on the other side of the city.”

“Was it really that dangerous down there?”

Ryoka looked inquiringly at Ceria. The half-Elf hesitated. She didn’t want to lie, but she didn’t want to tell the truth either. Even remembering the ordeal made her shudder.

“It was—bad. Very bad.”

She didn’t press for details, but Ryoka’s expression told Ceria she would listen. And Ceria knew she had to tell her. Slowly, she began to relate the entire tale to Ryoka, skipping over only the parts that were too hard to tell her, the details of the pit.

“Near the end, I think we were all a bit insane, even after the spell had ended. We made a lot of bad mistakes, and we lost the majority of the

treasure because we made a mistake.”

“It wasn’t your fault. None of you were thinking straight.”

“That’s true enough, but we should have fallen back. If we’d just taken the time...”

Again, Ceria had to make herself break off. There was no use going over the moment again and again. She turned the topic away from the past and onto the future instead. She made her tone lighter.

“After Yvlon gets treated and we’ve had another day to rest, we’re going to have to think hard about what we want to do next.”

“As adventurers, you mean?”

“Not that. I mean, not yet. I think we’re all in this now; we’ve been bit by the adventuring beast. But we need to improve ourselves first. We all leveled up from that dungeon—several times actually! But if we want to continue, we need to get those artifacts analyzed. They’re the difference between us being Silver-rank and Gold-rank.”

Ryoka nodded, thinking hard.

“Any idea how you could do that? I have one idea, but it would be... risky...”

“No need for risk. I know how to get everything looked at. It’s just a matter of time and effort.”

“Really? How?”

Ceria drained most of her mug, grimacing as she remembered it wasn’t water she was drinking.

“One place where we know we’d find people able to dispel the magic and maybe even repair the artifacts is Invrisil.”

“The City of Adventurers?”

“Everyone just has to mention that.”

The half-Elf rolled her eyes and laughed with Ryoka. But then she grew serious again.

“Yes. It’s one of the most famous cities on the continent for a reason. It’s the center of the Human lands, and famous teams pass through there all the time. If there were any place aside from Wistram where we’d get the gear looked at, it’s there.”

“Sounds good to me. Only one problem though—Isn’t Invrisil over four hundred miles north of here?”

“Six hundred? Something huge. Anyways, none of us want to make the journey, but that’s the place we have to be. A trip would take weeks—

maybe as much as a month and it would take far too much coin and time, not to mention the danger if people knew what we were carrying. But...”

“But...?”

Ceria grinned.

“Well, we were talking about it last night. This morning, rather, while we were getting over our last hangover. If it’s too much time and effort for the four of us to go north, why not hire someone who can get there faster? Someone we can trust? They could take the gold and get the gear analyzed, and then send us a [Message] spell and ask what we want to do and bring the gear back. Of course, we’d have to have complete faith in the Runner brave enough to do all that...”

At first, Ryoka’s expression was intent, but then her face went slack with surprise. By the time Ceria had finished, she was shaking her head.

“That’s a lot of trust to put in a Runner. I wouldn’t trust anyone like that, myself.”

“Are you sure?”

Ceria teased Ryoka.

“You’re the person who saved the original Horns of Hammerad all that time ago. And you went into the crypts to rescue me. I’d trust you with our gear and coin, and so would Yvlon. Pisces is on the fence, and Ksmvr just doesn’t know you that well. But if we got you an escort—another Runner who can fight maybe—the real issue is how you’ll carry all that gear without attracting attention.”

The young woman’s expression was bemused.

“I...may have something that could help with that. But before we go to all that trouble, I might have an even better idea. I happen to know a local expert in magic myself.”

“Really? Who?”

“I’ll introduce you.”

To Ceria’s incredulous surprise, Ryoka unbuckled her Runner’s belt and laid it on the table. She called out, and to Ceria’s astonishment she saw one of the compartments was *moving*.

“Hey. Ivolethe. You can come out here.”

The large pouch vibrated and Ceria leaned back as she heard a *voice*! It was a voice, but something was very strange about it. She heard someone speaking, that much was obvious. And yet—

She heard the words. It sounded like—‘are ye sure?’. But it couldn’t be. Ceria rubbed at her ears; the sound was almost ethereal, if that could apply to a voice. It felt almost as though she was hearing the words in her *mind*, like a stray thought. Then Ryoka opened the pouch and something flew out.

A Frost Faerie, a Winter Sprite, one of the beings of winter Ceria had seen every year, flew into the air, whirling as vapor trails formed behind her. Ceria gasped and pushed her chair back in instinctive surprise. And fear. She hadn’t forgotten how the faeries had attacked her last time she’d met, and all half-Elves had learned very early on that the Winter Sprites were not friendly towards them.

But something was different about this faerie. She wasn’t the half-blurred form Ceria saw in the sky. Ceria knew the faeries had their own glamor, an illusion she could only partly see through thanks to her Elven heritage. But in the confines of the room, the magic that kept her from being seen and heard was gone.

She was—real. So real and delicate and wondrous that Ceria couldn’t believe her eyes. But what her eyes saw made her stare even harder.

She saw something else, behind the form Ryoka saw. She saw a flash of color—a face, far larger than the tiny faerie’s wrinkling her nose at Ceria in displeasure. The elfin being flicked her hair—

And then the image was gone. The tiny faerie flipped her hair, flipped Ceria off, and then jumped up onto the mug with the drinks. She dunked her head in it and drank, lowering the level of the liquid quite a bit. Then she sat on the cup and glared at both Ceria and Ryoka.

“I do not wish to speak to the offspring of whores and slatterns.”

“That’s a rude way to say hello.”

Ryoka glared at the tiny faerie whom she introduced as Ivolethe. Ceria just stared, awestruck. When she finally found her voice, all she could do was stammer.

“How did you—do you know what—Ryoka?”

The young woman was grinning like a child holding a huge sweet.

“She’s a friend of mine, Ceria. A Frost Faerie. And she’s teaching me their magic.”

“*Their* magic?”

Ceria's eyes turned back to Ivolethe. The tiny faerie made another rude gesture.

"Don't stare at me so, bastard-daughter!"

The words stung and brought Ceria back to earth. Ryoka frowned hard at the tiny faerie and pushed her into the cup. Ivolethe spluttered and shook liquid off her wings, shouting in outrage.

"Stop that. Ceria's done nothing wrong. Why do your people hate her so much?"

The faerie sneered at Ryoka.

"We don't hate her, fool! We hate what she has become, what her existence *means*! Ask her about her people and their sin!"

Ceria bit her lip as the faerie spoke. She didn't know about sin—but she knew what the faerie meant. Ryoka glanced at her face and scowled at Ivolethe again.

"Stop being rude. I asked you to come out because I thought you could help, not shout insults. Calm down."

"Would you like a drink?"

Ceria offered her mug to the faerie. Ivolethe snorted and kicked the mug back.

"I won't drink from your cup, half-breed!"

Ryoka's eyes narrowed.

"Ivolethe. She offered you her cup. That was an act of good faith."

"I piss in your good faith!"

The faerie shouted at Ceria, but Ryoka flicked her back into the mug again. When she came out *shrieking* in outrage, Ceria just sighed and spoke to Ryoka.

"I don't think it's worth it, Ryoka."

"I do. And if Ivolethe is my friend, she'd heed my request."

Something about the way Ryoka phrased her statement spoke to Ceria. It certainly had an impact on Ivolethe. The faerie stared up at her, incredulous.

“Ye’d invoke our friendship? For *her*?”

“Absolutely. She’s my friend as well. And all I’m asking is if you’d consider looking at her magical artifacts.”

“No! Nae! Never a million times over!”

“Ivolethe...”

“Never a million times and one!”

“Come on.”

“*No!*”

Ceria stared at the two arguing and rubbed her eyes. She stared at her mug and decided she wasn’t doing any more drinking, possibly ever. Ryoka kept pressing the insistent Frost Faerie.

“Ivolethe, I’m asking you as a friend. Unless your friendship with me isn’t worth that much?”

Ivolethe’s eyes narrowed dangerously, and her voice deepened far more than should be possible.

“Play no games with me, *mortal*. Friendship is not a bargaining tool.”

“Sorry.”

Ryoka actually looked *chastened*. Ivolethe fanned her wings out, sniffed, and then seemed to relent. She didn’t look directly at Ceria, but her tone made it clear she was speaking to both girls.

“Even if I did consent, my help would avail ye naught.”

“Why’s that? Can’t you read magic? I thought faeries knew more magic than any mortal.”

“True, but what we understand is not your odd system. I could read the flow of magic within such objects, but knowing the ken of such strange things is beyond me. The wh—the halfling is right. Find a proper spellcaster to do your work rather than bother me.”

With that, the faerie jumped back into the pouch and closed it in a huff, pausing only to drink Ryoka’s cup dry. Ryoka stared at Ceria and shrugged.

“Well, it was worth a shot.”

Ceria stared at her friend and shook her head very slowly.

“You’re going to have to explain what happened to *you* while I was away.”

The young woman grinned.

“I can do that. It’ll take a while, though.”

“We’ve got time. You could tell all of us over dinner. We could visit Yvlon then hear it from you.”

Ryoka nodded.

“Good idea. And while we do, I can talk to you about Erin.”

“What about Erin? Is she okay?”

“She’s in Celum right now.”

“*What?*”

“I’ll tell you the entire story, but the long and short of it is that she needs an escort. And we also need for Pisces to track down Toren—the skeleton.”

“Why?”

Ceria’s mind raced ahead of Ryoka’s answer and she groaned even as Ryoka told her.

“He’s done it. Pisces actually—no, maybe he just made one that could think. But that crazy fool actually—”

Ryoka frowned as she followed Ceria out the door. The half-Elf stomped down the corridor, suddenly in a foul mood.

“What’s he done? What’s this about Toren?”

“We’ll get Pisces to explain right now. If he’s not sober I’ll freeze him until he is. It’s his stupid idea with the undead. It goes all the way back to when we were at Wistram.”

Ceria paused as she reached the stairs leading down. She halted Ryoka silently. The young woman looked at her, and she had the presence of mind to whisper.

“What? What’s wrong?”

The half-Elf frowned. She lowered her voice to a whisper as well.

“Pisces and Ksmvr were down there with half the city drinking and having a party.”

“So?”

“Why’s it so quiet?”

They exchanged a look. Ceria raised her skeletal hand, calling magic into it. Ryoka pulled a bottle from her belt. The two crept down the stairs.

The two were ready for anything—bandits, a crazed mob, enemy mages, monsters—even an evil undead skeleton. But neither of them had expected the smartly dressed, professional [Butler] that stood in the middle of the common room, waiting for them to come down.

He was the odd thing out in the world of celebration and cheer. Pisces, Ksmvr, and the many, many guests in the inn were all paused in the midst of their reveling, staring at the man in his black uniform and trim mustache. He bowed to Ryoka, arm over his stomach as she descended, staring at him.

“Ryoka Griffin?”

Ceria looked over at her friend as every eye turned to the Runner. Ryoka had a dark look on her face as she stared at the man. She crossed her arms.

“Who’s asking?”

The [Butler] straightened and gave her a dignified nod of the head. His words were crisp and precise.

“My name is Reynold, Miss Griffin. I am a [Butler] in direct employ of the Reinhart house. I have come here at the orders of Lady Magnolia.”

Ceria had never wanted a [Butler]—she’d never considered even having one before now. But now she wanted one. She stared at the man, mind buzzing with the implications of what he’d just said. Lady *Magnolia*? She wanted Ryoka? Why?

Ryoka’s face was completely hostile as she stared at Reynold.

“Oh? And what does Magnolia want with me?”

The man gestured towards the door. Through it, Ryoka could see a carriage, sitting horseless on the street. But it was not a simple carriage. It had to be one of the nobility’s carriages, the kind pulled by magic creations similar in nature to the fire construct Ceria had faced in the dungeon.

“The coach awaits you outside. If you will come with us, we will bring you to the estate of Magnolia Reinhart.”

“And if I refuse?”

Ceria stared at her friend in shock. But Ryoka looked quite serious. Reynold nodded once.

“I will not force you to come with us.”

“Wise.”

Ryoka sneered down at the [Butler]. He raised one finger, cutting off her next words.

“However, I must caution you that Lady Magnolia did not send just me.”

“What?”

Outside the inn, the doors of the carriage slowly opened. Ceria saw someone emerge from the carriage, but it was not Lady Magnolia. Not Magnolia, and yet a tiny bell in Ceria’s head—her [Dangersense]—rang the instant she laid eyes on the woman.

Ressa, the head [Maid] in Lady Magnolia’s employ, stepped through the doors, staring around the room full of silent people as if they were specks of dirt and she had a dust cloth. She stopped, her black and white dress swirling around her as she met Ryoka’s eyes across the crowded room.

The older woman did not smile. She didn’t frown either; she just looked at Ryoka with cold eyes, weighing her up and down and finding her wanting as before. Ressa’s face was implacable as she looked Ryoka straight in the eye and spoke.

“Lady Reinhart is expecting you.”

3.10

Yvlon Byres knew the answer before they said it. She was not a silver-tongued socialite, but she had learned to read people's eyes as a child. She had learned to dance with words before she had picked up a sword. Of course, she'd left that world behind to become an adventurer, but some things never faded.

Now she sat still and kept her face still, hoping that she was wrong. But the [Healer] just shook his head as he tapped on the silver and black metal that had become part of Yvlon's body.

"I'm sorry Miss Byres. But I don't believe the metal can be removed."

"I see."

Yvlon's tone was light and free of negative emotion. She looked the man directly in the eye; an honest [Noble] would do no less. Feeling free to speak, the man went on, speaking candidly.

"I am not a high-level [Healer]. Perhaps one with a Skill might be able to deal with this...affliction. Or perhaps a [Bone Surgeon], although you would have to find a Gnoll tribe's [Healer] with such a rare class. As it is... I can do nothing."

The woman stared at her arms, at the metal that felt so alien and heavy on her skin. There was no pain—only a sense of invasiveness. She could feel the metal *in* her, and in truth she had expected no other answer from the man.

"What of the exterior?"

The tall, broad woman standing next to the [Healer] cleared her throat. She was a [Blacksmith], and she touched the cold metal with familiarity. Yvlon didn't mind the intrusion, although the [Healer] looked askance. But the [Blacksmith] only saw metal, and how it could be shaped.

"That I could cut away. The pieces below the skin—if that is anchored to bone I won't touch it. Normally we'd use a saw or snap the metal in two —"

"No."

The man hurriedly interjected and the broad-shoulder woman nodded placidly before continuing.

“—But with the right blade we could cut the metal. It’s warped; lost a lot of its strength in the melting. An enchanted dagger would cut most of it off and we could sand the rest smooth. It’s not easy, but it is doable.”

Yvlon looked at the [Healer] to see his opinion. The man nodded reluctantly.

“It would certainly allow the skin to breathe and prevent much of the possible infection. But even so, the metal has bonded with bone. Your arms —”

“I understand. Thank you.”

She couldn’t bear to hear any more. Both man and woman exchanged uncertain glances. At last, the [Healer] spoke again.

“I’ll leave you to get dressed.”

“And I will see if I can find a blade good enough to use. It will have to be enchanted—Dwarven-craft weapons might work, but even that would involve sharpening...”

Their words fell on deaf ears. Yvlon waited until they’d left, smiling politely and thanking them for their time—and paying them for their efforts. Then she sat back in the small room the [Healer] had examined her in and reached for her clothes.

She had still worn a breast band of course, but she had had to take off the clothing on her upper body to expose her shoulders and arms. Yvlon gazed at them now, and saw the metal. It had once been her armor, but now...

It looked almost like a scab. A dirty, discolored plating of metal that ran from her shoulders down to her hands. It wasn’t one unsplit seam either; jagged cracks had broken around her joints, allowing her to move her arms, albeit with difficulty. It was heavy. And as Yvlon stared at her arms, her shirt in one hand, her eyes filled with tears.

It was a moment of weakness. The only one she could afford, when everyone’s eyes weren’t on her. Yvlon dropped her shirt and felt her eyes sting as the world blurred.

Cool composure. Politeness at all times. It was the mark of a Byres, and she had kept the mask up. But she hadn’t dared invite her friends, the other Horns of Hammerad. She hadn’t wanted them to hear the news, see the looks on their faces.

Her hands were trembling, but all Yvlon saw was metal. Ugly metal. It wasn’t beautiful, not like the silver she had worn, the silver which she’d

been so proud of, her family's colors and fortune—the name she had taken for her adventuring group. It was ugly and tarnished and black.

Just like her.

More tears trickled down her cheek. Yvlon wiped at her eyes clumsily, feeling the hard metal brush against her eyes.

“Oh no. Not this. Honor and hearth. Please, not...”

It wasn't *fair*. That was what she wanted to say, but wasn't it what she deserved? And she'd been the only one with a weapon. Ksmvr had been down, Pisces and Ceria's magic had failed—

She'd done what she had to do. It was her duty, and she'd been prepared for death. But not this.

“Not *this*.”

Her arms. The metal was so dull. Yvlon shook again. Strong. She had to be strong. If she let her friends down—

Would they think less of her? Abandon her? She had failed once. How could she tell them? What could she say? She'd already demanded almost all the gold they'd earned. What about this?

“I don't know.”

It had been so easy a month ago. She'd been so sure. Yvlon pulled her tunic over her head, slowly, clumsily. The [Healer] had offered to help her, but this she had to do herself. The fabric was far too loose for her comfort, but it was the only way she could get it over her arms. She couldn't even raise them fully over her head; the metal dug too much into her flesh to let her.

Part of Yvlon just wanted to sleep. To go to sleep and forget. But then she might dream she was in the pit again, imagining she was one of her long-dead ancestors. Or worse, she might dream of Skinner, the crawling monster with crimson eyes and the undead that struck down each of her friends in slow motion. Yvlon shuddered. Her eyes filled again.

Someone hammered on her door. Yvlon sat bolt upright. In an instant, her eyes stopped stinging, and she used her shirt to scrub at her face.

“Enter.”

When the panting young man pushed open the door he didn't notice Yvlon's red eyes; he only saw her arms, and even that only held his attention for a second. He stopped and bobbed his head awkwardly to her, as if she were his liege lady instead of a common adventurer.

“Pardon, Miss Yvlon, but there's trouble at The Nobleman's Disgrace!”

“What?”

Yvlon said the words and then remembered; that was the inn they were all staying at.

“What trouble?”

“I don’t know. A coach arrived—a fancy noble’s coach, one of the ones pulled by magic! And a man and a woman came out, and then they said they were going to take a Runner away!”

A Runner? Yvlon’s brows furrowed as she tried to make sense of everything.

“Who? And what does this have to do with us?”

The young man could only gabble on as he tried to explain things from his limited perspective.

“The Runner? Her name was Ryoka Griffin—”

“*Ryoka?*”

“That’s right! And she said she wasn’t going, and the woman insisted, and then your Captain—the half-Elf—she said she wasn’t going either and folks started drawing their swords!”

Yvlon didn’t wait to hear anything else. She was out of her chair and pushing past the surprised young man in an instant. Her grief, her feelings of pain and regret—all of it she gladly surrendered to adrenaline and the need for action.

“My sword—”

She didn’t have one. Yvlon snapped at the young man.

“Get me a sword!”

She charged out of the building and onto the street, running in the direction of the inn. She didn’t know why Ryoka was here, but she had saved Ceria, and if the other Horns of Hammerad were going to fight, so was Yvlon. She would not let her party die again.

Sometimes Ceria wondered if she could ever have a peaceful life. If she quit casting magic and stopped going on adventures and just lived in a quiet place somewhere for the rest of her life, wouldn’t that be worthwhile? She’d never have to fight monsters and she wouldn’t wake up with bugs crawling in her mouth while it rained. She could be happy.

But the flaw with that idea was that even if Ceria didn't get into trouble, her friends would. Like Ryoka, and Erin for example. The trouble with those two girls was that they tended to attract monsters and chaos like a tower attracted thunderbolts in a storm.

And it seemed like they were getting better at it, or at least Ryoka was. Ceria stood warily by her friend's side, staring at a tall, austere [Maid] standing in the middle of The Nobleman's Disgrace. Despite the countless swords, daggers, and other weapons being pointed at her, the woman appeared completely unconcerned. And Ceria's [Dangersense] was going off, warning her in no uncertain terms.

To be clear, it wasn't the Horns of Hammerad, Ryoka, or even Ressa or the [Butler] who had unsheathed their blades. Rather, it was the clientele of the inn, the revelers who'd come to bask in the presence of the Horns of Hammerad, hear stories and get drunk.

Ceria agonized. How had it come to this? She'd just said that Ryoka wasn't being taken anywhere against her will, and these *idiots* had drawn weapons. On a servant employed by *Magnolia Reinhart*!

And now this servant was demanding that Ryoka went with them again. Ceria gritted her teeth as the young woman standing by her side glared at the maid she'd called Ressa. The half-Elf knew her friend was stubborn, and she had no idea why Magnolia Reinhart wanted her, but she hoped she'd at least be tactful—

"Fuck you. I'm not going."

If Ceria could have closed her ears off to not hear that, she would. Was Ryoka *insane*? Ceria was no native to this continent, but she had heard so many stories of the Five Families and their influence. You did *not* refuse their requests without good reason.

But it appeared that Ressa had fully expected Ryoka's refusal. The [Maid]'s expression did not change; that was to say, she continued looking at Ryoka like a filthy insect that was about to be smeared on the ground.

"You have no choice. Magnolia Reinhart has requested your presence. You will come with me."

"And if I refuse?"

"Feel free to try."

What could they do? Ceria looked around the inn. The other patrons were looking at the [Maid] and her, clearly waiting for her instruction. If she asked them to she had no doubt they'd throw the maid out of the inn.

And then Magnolia Reinhart would probably burn down the inn and throw them off a *cliff*.

It had to be said again. Ceria stepped forwards in front of Ryoka protectively. Pisces, staggering slightly, took her right side, puffed up with alcohol and bravado. Ksmvr didn't do the same—because he was flanking the [Maid], ready to charge her. Ceria could only hope he'd wait for her to make the first move if it came to that.

"If Ryoka doesn't want to go, she's not going."

Again, the maid only flicked her eyes at Ceria and the other Horns of Hammerad dismissively. It was as if she couldn't see how outnumbered she was.

"I would advise you to stay out of this matter."

That was it. Ten words. Ressa knew they were adventurers; she had to know that. And she also knew the mood in the inn was against her for all her mistress's influence, but she was still warning Ceria. That made the half-Elf hesitate, but what could she do? Let Ryoka be abducted? No.

She thought fast.

"In that case, we'll go with Ryoka. If you take her, we'll be right by her side."

Ryoka blinked. She turned to Ceria at the same time Pisces did. But it was Ressa who spoke. Her eyes focused on Ceria's face and then moved to Pisces and Ksmvr. Her eyes lingered longest on Ksmvr, although there was not a hint of expression in her face or tone.

"Absolutely not."

"Why not?"

Ceria challenged the woman, trying not to flinch from the cold stare. Did she have some kind of intimidation Skill? It almost felt like she was staring at Skinner again. But she held her ground despite the sweat running down her back.

"My orders were for Ryoka alone."

"If you really want Ryoka to go with you at least tell us why."

"She knows why."

Ressa looked back at Ryoka. Ceria looked at her friend and saw a faint grimace cross Ryoka's face. There was some history here, she knew, but she didn't have time to ask for an explanation. Ceria changed tack.

"Then reassure us. Ryoka is our friend; at least promise us she'll come to no harm while she's with you."

That would be simple enough, right? If they could nail her down to a promise or—

“No.”

It felt like *everyone* blinked when they heard that word. Ressa’s face was smooth, though. She shook her head.

“No promises. No bargaining. Ryoka Griffin will come with me. Or I will be forced to bring her against her will.”

“Oh really?”

Pisces’ slightly slurred voice ran out. He took an unsteady step towards Ressa. The [Maid]’s left eye twitched as she focused on him, but she didn’t make any other move. Pisces pointed at her, sneering.

“You seem quite confident, Miss Maid, that we will so obediently roll over and accede to your Mistress’s wishes. But the good people of this city are not so spineless as to obey even one of the Five Families’ minions when they come here to abduct an innocent Runner.”

His words seemed to have the opposite effect that he had intended. Half the people in the inn shifted uncomfortably at the mention of the Five Families, and they seemed to realize they were pointing weapons at a servant of a Reinhart. Their blades lowered almost as one, although most still kept them out.

Pisces, oblivious, kept going.

“And as to your presumptuous statement—I feel obliged to point out the obvious. You are outnumbered and I very much doubt your [Butler] is a master of arms. To quote an oft-repeated phrase, you and what army will take Ryoka Griffin away?”

Ressa made no immediate response. She just stared at Pisces with contempt. Meanwhile, Ceria and every person in the inn slowly filled in her unspoken reply.

What army? What army would back Magnolia Reinhart? It was more like a question of which army *wouldn’t* mobilize at her word. Every garrison of every major city in the north would back her if she so ordered.

Across the bar, someone slipped out the back. Ceria saw the movement, and then saw weapons slowly being sheathed, and people starting to back away. Drunk bravado had had a moment to sober, and now people were correctly realizing that this standoff was *not* something they wanted to be involved in.

Pisces seemed quite oblivious to this. He didn't notice as more people began abandoning the tables around him and retreated from being active participants in the discussion to mere innocent bystanders, standing at the far end of the room. Meanwhile, the maid was waiting. Just waiting.

She wasn't even really listening to Pisces or her, Ceria realized. Ressa was just waiting for Ryoka's response again. And it was clear that saying 'no' a second time wouldn't be a wise idea.

"Ryoka?"

She murmured to her friend. Ryoka was breathing heavily, and her jaw was clenched. She had something in her hand—a potion? Maybe a weapon of some kind, an alchemist's weapon. Ceria wished she could tell Ryoka not to use it at any cost, but she had no idea what Ryoka's relationship with Magnolia was. What should she do? If she—

"Ceria!"

Someone shouted her name. Ceria jerked, and then Yvlon rushed into the inn, a sword in her hands. She looked around for an enemy wildly, spotted Ressa. She froze in place, and the color drained from her face.

"Miss Ressa?"

"Yvlon Byres."

It was remarkable how the [Maid] didn't react to Yvlon's appearance. She just stared at the woman, noted her arms, and dismissed her in an instant.

"Put the sword down. Lady Magnolia has requested Ryoka Griffin's presence."

"I—"

Yvlon might have been expecting trouble, but she was clearly thrown by Ressa's presence. Thrown into a barn door, by the look on her face. She wavered, but then gripped the blade more firmly with both hands.

"No."

"What did you say?"

The maid's voice was cold. Yvlon's was just as chilly.

"Ryoka is my friend, and Ceria's. If she doesn't wish to go with you, I will back her. Even if it means defying Aunt Magnolia's request."

"That is Lady Magnolia to you. And you would be well advised not to involve yourself in this, girl."

The two women locked eyes, but Yvlon refused to back down. Ceria vaguely remembered—the Byres house was one of the Reinhart family's

branch houses, weren't they? They were definitely subservient in some way.

"Yvlon—"

"Say the word, Ceria."

Yvlon's arms trembled, but her gaze was square on Ressa. The woman only sighed; she seemed more irritated by Yvlon's refusal to budge than worried about the sword aimed at her. She turned back to Ryoka.

"Well? Will you come peacefully?"

Ryoka was visibly hesitating. She bit her lip as she glared at Ressa. Ceria was tense; she didn't know what was coming next and she feared whatever answer Ryoka might give. But then she saw Ksmvr raise his third hand.

"If I may have your attention?"

Ressa looked at him and her gaze could have frozen ice. Ksmvr paid no attention; his other two hands were holding a dagger and a bottle respectively.

"I advise you to surrender and retreat before my Captain orders me to attack. I am fairly confident it will result in your death or maiming."

Ceria felt like she had inhaled her tongue. Everyone else in the inn goggled at Ksmvr. Ressa said only one word as her eyes narrowed.

"What?"

The Antinium nodded at Ressa.

"You have the stance of a trained warrior, but you lack armor and visible arms. Unless you hold a magical item of considerable potency or possess unarmed combat Skills, I believe I will be able to kill you if my allies and I attack in tandem."

The Antinium finished with this confident declaration and waited for the maid's response. After a moment she realized people were staring at him.

"...What? Are we not intending to kill her if she insists on taking Ryoka?"

Ceria's head was starting to hurt. She pointed at the Antinium.

"Ksmvr—stand down. No one is going to hurt her, and certainly not *kill* her."

"Ah. My mistake."

Ksmvr nodded apologetically and stepped back. Ressa turned back to Ryoka. Ceria tried to quiet her beating heart. Try again?

"Can we talk about this? If Ryoka doesn't want to leave—"

“Fine. I’ll go.”

Ceria turned in astonishment. Ryoka sighed and stepped forwards. Ressa regarded her with what looked like surprise as well.

“Ryoka?”

The Runner shrugged at Ceria, looking resigned.

“I’ve got no choice. I knew this was coming. Ceria, I’ve got to go.”

“But—”

The look in Ryoka’s eyes told her not to ask any more questions. Ceria glanced around and remembered her audience. She held Ryoka’s gaze.

“You’re sure?”

“Pretty much.”

Ryoka turned and glared at Ressa.

“Where is Magnolia now?”

“Invrissil. You will be taken to her estate which lies next to the city.”

The name of the city made Ryoka and Ceria blink. She saw Ryoka turn and look back at her, and then her friend turned back to Ressa.

“Okay. I’ll go. But on one condition. Give me fifteen minutes to prepare before we leave.”

The maid seemed to think this over. She looked sharply at Ryoka.

“Running will do you no good.”

“I know.”

The two locked gazes for one more second. Then Ressa’s head dipped almost imperceptibly.

“I will wait for you in the carriage. Do not force me to retrieve you.”

Without another word, she turned and walked out of the inn. Ceria stared at her back in shock, and then saw the door to the carriage open. Ryoka sighed softly, and looked at her.

“You’ll have to tell Erin.”

Then the chaos began and Ceria could only try and keep up.

Holy crap, this is it. Either I’m dead or I’m going to be interrogated and tortured horribly before I die. Or maybe I survive, but I’m not placing my bets on a happy ending.

The instant Ressa walks out the door it’s all go. I turn and drag Ceria upstairs; too slowly, because people are already crowding around me and

the other Horns of Hammerad, asking questions and shouting, speculating.

“Out of the way!”

I shout at them as I push for the stairs. Ceria seems to get what I’m trying to do and helps me push.

“Move aside! We have to hurry!”

They don’t want to let us go. People are pulling at me, asking me how I know Magnolia Reinhart, what my business is with her. I want to punch them but I don’t have time for a brawl—

“[Frozen Wind].”

Someone whispers the spell. I hear *shrieks*, and then feel the cold air blow past me, freezing me in an instant. Pisces lowers his hands as the crowd suddenly backs up. The spell he cast wasn’t deadly, but damn, it looks painful. He pushes both of us up the stairs and Yvlon and Ksmvr are behind us in a flash.

“In here.”

I push into Ceria’s room and take a breath. She looks at me, wide-eyed and bursting with questions, but I know I can’t answer any of them right now. I don’t even know if I should. I can’t drag her into this. God, what is Magnolia going to ask me?

“Ryoka, what—”

“Fifteen minutes. Probably more like ten.”

I cut her off as I snap. I pace around the room, already trying to figure out the fastest way through the streets.

“Figure out how much gold you need to give me, and get all those damaged artifacts and whatever else you want me to get analyzed. I’ll take it—I’ve got a bag of holding of my own.”

“You *do*?”

I touch the bag Teriarch gave me at my side.

“It should fit everything. Can you put a bag of holding in a bag of holding?”

“Do not attempt that.”

Pisces stares at me intently as he stands against one wall. Ksmvr and Yvlon are just staring as Ceria sits on her bed. I nod at him.

“I’ll keep the backpack and the other pouch separate, then. Have it all ready before I get back; I need to go and that stupid maid isn’t going to wait.”

“We can do that.”

Yvlon speaks, looking at the others for confirmation. I meet her eyes; should I say anything? We didn't even say hello, and suddenly we're doing this. I still remember punching her—

“Ryoka, are you sure about this? You don't have to go if you're not sure.”

I tear my eyes away and look at Ceria.

“I think I have to. If I don't, there will be trouble.”

Now that I know how big a fish Magnolia Reinhart is, I have no desire to push her. Pisces nods.

“It would be best if Miss Ryoka went with the servants without a fuss. We are only fortunate that the fools down below were not completely insensible to reason, or else we all might be in a serious predicament.”

We all stare at him. Pisces still reeks of booze, but he doesn't look nearly as unsteady as he was a few seconds ago. Ceria gapes at him.

“Wait. You did that on *purpose*, didn't you?”

He sneers. Of course. I nod at him, and turn to the door.

“Get everything you need to give me. I'll be back—”

“Where are you going?”

Ceria looks worried. I turn.

“Runner's Guild.”

“*What?*”

No time to answer. I rush down the stairs, nearly trampling the innkeeper who's trying to listen at the door, and push out of the crowd. I get one glimpse at the coach—surrounded by a crowd of people who don't quite dare to get any closer—and then I'm running full-tilt down the icy street. Damn. My feet are cold. At least I have one of Erin's jars of Corusdeer soup. I should have gotten more.

As I run I fumble at my belt. I call out, ignoring the looks I'm getting as I run down the street towards the Guild.

“Ivolethe. You're going to have to get out.”

The faerie flies from my pouch and up to my head.

“You go to meet this woman? The others seem truly fearful of her name; it betokens much of her, does it not?”

“It does. And you—you've got to stay away from her. You can't go in her house. Magnolia's extremely dangerous.”

Is she? I've never figured out how dangerous she is, but I know that she's smart and she employs [Assassins] and she's rich. I'm going with maximum paranoia to be on the safe side, and at the top of my list is not getting Ivoethe in the same position as she was with Persua.

"I will follow ye."

Ivoethe agrees readily, which makes me feel relieved. But then she flies closer to my face.

"Know this, Ryoka. I am your friend, but in matters of life and death, I must not interfere. We have broken the rule twice; but we had cause and sacrifice, you understand? It must not, will not happen thrice. Remember that."

"I understand."

I'm on my own. Ivoethe nods, and flies up. She lets me run on until I get to the Runner's Guild. How much time has passed? Only three minutes? Five?

I *slam* the doors open and rush up to the front desk. I thrust aside a female Runner, ignoring her shout of anger and point at the [Receptionist]. He blinks at me.

"Get me...every delivery you have for Invrilil."

"What?"

Everyone says that word. Why? It just wastes time. I pant as I clarify my statement in as few words as possible.

"I'm about to go directly to Invrilil. Today. If you have a multi-part delivery...Courier deliveries...anything. I want it."

Multi-part deliveries are like Courier deliveries, only the people sending the packages can't pay the exorbitant amounts demanded by Couriers. So they hire City Runners to take the delivery as far as they can go, and then another Runner will complete the request. It's a useful relay system, although it still costs a lot.

The man at the desk spreads his hands as I try to calculate how much the carriage can carry.

"I'm sorry Miss...Ryoka, is it? I can't just—"

I grab him and drag him over the desk. He yelps, and I growl at him.

“I don’t have time for this. *Give me the deliveries.*”

Ten minutes later, I’m rushing back down the street. Turns out even a [Receptionist] can run fast when you’re literally kicking him around. I have a bundle of deliveries in my hand and more in my pack—some are damn *heavy*. Two more Runners are racing after me, carrying more things bound for Invril. I couldn’t take everything, but I got a huge amount.

Ressa *stares* at me as I fling open the carriage door and start shoving packages inside. Her intimidating glare* doesn’t stop me from piling the rich seat next to her with deliveries. I’m secretly enjoying every second of this, but I keep my face straight.

*Yeah, I’ll admit it, she scares me a bit. She’s like a perfect Victorian maid if you secretly suspected that they could kill you with their bare hands.

“Sorry, you’re going to have to budge over. I’ve got some really big stuff to take as well.”

“What are you doing?”

“Deliveries. I’m a Runner.”

I slam the door in Ressa’s face before she can respond and turn to the panting Runners behind me. They’re breathing hard from that little run? Disgraceful.

“Okay, load the rest of the deliveries into the coach.”

Is it a coach or carriage? Wait, they’re both the same thing, aren’t they? My mind’s running too fast to focus on anything. I point to the vehicle, ignoring the hesitation on the faces of the Runners.

“Go on.”

“Are you sure?”

The female Runner looks hesitant. Understandable I guess; this definitely doesn’t look like a bulk transport. I nod.

“Get it on there. Hurry up!”

The voice of command is a wonderful thing. They get to work, and I look around and see if I can spot Ceria and the others. I wonder if Ressa will snap when I bring all of their gear as well.

God. This is the stupidest thing I’ve ever done, and I’ve got a list. But it makes sense! I’m getting a free ride to Invril, or rather I don’t have any choice, so I might as well milk it for all I’ve got. I’ll get paid, I can help my friends out—

The Runners are hesitating as they open the door and find Ressa glaring at them. I think they'd be more comfortable with a snake in the carriage. I certainly would be.

"Well? Go on; toss it in. Ignore the [Maid]."

I'm playing a dangerous game here. It'll probably end in me getting my ass handed to me, but I don't care. If Ressa thinks she can push me around

—
Well, she's right, but I'm getting my revenge this way. I gesture at the Runners, and hear a cough behind me.

"Miss? There is a trunk, as well as space above."

I turn and see the [Butler]. Honestly, I'd put him completely out of my mind. But now that I look at him and his dapper suit—I sort of want to deck him as well as Ressa. He reminds me too much of my folks' home. True, they didn't have servants, but...

Actually, we did, didn't we? I mean, it wasn't as if we had our own butlers and so on, but gardeners, pool people, personal masseuses and so on—that's a lot of people at your beck and call.

Damn it, mom and dad.

Anyways, what was he saying? A trunk?

"Where?"

He points. My eyes find a subtly disguised trunk on the back of the big carriage.

Holy crap, there is! Do all carriages have trunks? Well...obviously. I haven't ridden in any before now, in my defense. And can it fit all the deliveries? I open it and peer inside. Wow. It can!

But then, this is no ordinary carriage. If the ones from my world are like regular cars, this one's pretty much a combination of a truck, limousine, and race car. It's *huge*, plenty big enough to hold a full assortment of passengers and the deliveries I'm bringing, and it looks lavish. Plush upholstery, gilded exterior—magic horses. Did I mention that?

"Ryoka!"

I turn from supervising the Runners as they pull the deliveries out of the carriage and redeploy them in the trunk to see Ceria and the other Horns of Hammerad. I realize I haven't even said hello to Yvlon, Pisces, or...the Antinium.

Who is he? I remember Klbkch and Pawn, but this is the other one, isn't it? How many Antinium does Erin know? I see they've got a bunch of

pretty beat-up looking weapons in their hands. Are those the magical artifacts? God, they look so beat up. They don't even glow—well, one is glowing, but it's very faint.

“Here.”

They shove the weapons at me and I fumble at my side. My bag of holding can hold everything they've got—one buckler, a sword, the blade of a sword, and a dagger. The pack and small bag that looks sort of like mine* goes into the trunk. Ceria pours gold into the bag, several hundred gold coins! The crowd watching us is murmuring, and I just pray like hell they don't try and rush us.

*Definitely a bag of holding. I mean, who *wouldn't* use one? Forget wallets; I want this thing if I ever get back to my world. I can literally fit the kitchen sink in here.

“Do you have everything?”

“Think so. Did I miss any items?”

“No. And you've got the gold...? Good. And you know what to do?”

“I'll get all of it looked at. Don't worry.”

“And if you have to make a decision—”

“If I need to I'll send a [Message] spell. I've got it.”

Ceria and Pisces try to tell me how to find the best mages to analyze the weapons. Yvlon tells me what price is worth paying for a mage and when I should walk away. Ksmvr tells me that I should attempt to use aggression and tact in my dealings, whatever that means. And then...then we just stand around awkwardly.

“Well. I guess I've got to go.”

Ceria smiles at me, worry clear in her eyes.

“I don't believe this is happening, Ryoka. This is so—sudden.”

“Fortuitous, perhaps.”

Pisces remarks as he nods at the carriage. He eyes me.

“I would advise you to guard your tongue when you are meeting with Magnolia Reinhart, Miss Ryoka. It would be...unfortunate if something untoward were to occur on your journey.”

“It would be a zemblanity, you mean?”

“A...pardon me?”

I grin at Pisces's face. He's not the only person who can use words to befuddle people. I turn and nod at Yvlon. My eyes fix on her arms—I'd barely seen them before, but looking at them now, I'm both sickened and

amazed at how her skin seems to meld with the metal. But I jerk my gaze away and meet Yvlon's eyes instead. She nods at me, smiling with a trace of bitterness.

"Good luck, Ryoka."

"Thanks."

It feels like there's a thousand things we should say, but that's all I have time for. I nod to Ksmvr—not much to say to him, really, and then I look at Ceria.

"I'll be back soon."

That's all. I know, it's like the worst thing I could say if I were in an action movie or a horror film. But really, I feel the same sort of foreboding come over me as I open the door of the carriage and step inside. Ressa doesn't even look at me as I scoot into the spacious interior and wave at the Horns of Hammerad.

Famous last words. But I said them—and I did all this, offer to analyze the weapons, even grab all those deliveries—because I am afraid. I'm doing this because I want to believe there's a time after meeting Magnolia. There probably is. I shouldn't worry, but part of me does.

I ran from her at first. It was so long ago, I'd nearly forgotten. But she knows. She was the first person to figure out where I came from, and I still remember how she could command me so easily. And now I'm on a trip to meet with her. I can only pray it's not one-way.

"Well?"

I try to make the word challenging as the door closes and I look at Ressa. She glances up at me, and turns her head.

"Reynold? Take us away."

I hear the [Butler] moving outside the carriage—he's in a pretty decent seat outside, even if it is exposed to the wind. He doesn't crack the whip since there are no horses; rather, the coach begins to accelerate with only the faintest shift in equilibrium.

I stare out the window and see the world moving with surprising speed as the butler drives us down the street. I look outside and then see something odd.

People. Waving at us. Their mouths are open, and I open the door slightly to confirm what's happening. Noise immediately enters the carriage. Not just noise; cheering.

Yes, that's right. There's people lining the streets, the crowd at the inn and countless people who came out to see what the fuss was about. Now they're giving us a sendoff as if we were a bunch of celebrities—which we sort of are, I guess.

It's still unbelievable to see. A sea of faces passes me by as the coach picks up speed. The citizens of Ocre are waving and laughing and even throwing...is that colored flour? Why? They're waving and cheering—do they even know why Ressa is here or that it's me? Or are they just that thrilled by the nobility?

“You fucking people.”

I pull the door open and flip off the cheering crowd. I hear the cheering falter, much to my satisfaction. Then I notice Ressa looking disapprovingly at me, which is to say like normal. I pull my hand back in and flip her off as well. That's the beauty of the middle finger. It's multi-purpose and reusable.

Once again though, the maid doesn't rise to my bait. Ressa just sits in the carriage, not staring at me but rather looking out the window on her side in silence. I can tell she's aware of me, but she's giving me the cold shoulder. The freezing shoulder, if I'm honest.

As we speed out the gates to the city, I see the landscape begin to blur as we move impossibly fast. Holy crap, how fast are we going? I barely feel the acceleration, but it feels as if we're easily passing eighty miles an hour. How can we do that in the snow? And what if we hit a rock? Or a pothole? These roads aren't like the highways in my world!

But Ressa appears unconcerned, and I can't even feel the coach jolting along. It must be magic that's keeping us stable as well. That's a lazy explanation, but I don't exactly have the opportunity to analyze the way the wheels are interacting with the ground.

I stare back at Ressa. She's still sitting and not looking at me. And as the adrenaline and excitement of the last fifteen minutes finally fades from my system, I realize this is happening.

I'm going to meet Magnolia Reinhart. I'm not ready for this.

And I'm nervous. I stare harder at Ressa, but I know she's not going to talk to me. She doesn't like me, probably because I'm a rude asshole. So what should I do?

I could...sit here. I guess. The inside of the carriage is very spacious and I can stretch out my legs. There's plenty of room, and even a small *table* in the center. There's something covered by dark blue cloth on it. I

wonder what it is? Yeah, I could be a peaceful guest and let this [Butler] and [Maid] take me to Magnolia like a good little girl.

Or—

The dark upholstery of the carriage is almost sinfully comfortable. I sink into it, and then twist. Ressa's eyes turn as I prop my legs up on my side of the carriage and put my bare (and dirty) feet on the lovely padding. I cross my arms as I sit with my back to one wall of the carriage and stare at her. She looks pointedly at my feet but I don't move them.

"So. You did it. You got me here, and now you're delivering me to Magnolia. Well done, you."

No response. Ressa stares at me for another second and then goes back to staring out of the window. I sigh, loudly and as obnoxiously as possible.

"So what does Magnolia want from me? More juice? Something else? Or does she just want to chat?"

Silence. I edge a bit lower in my seat, so I'm nearly lying down.

"You know, it's odd that she sent *you* to pick me up. Aren't you the most important servant? The demi-head honcho? Isn't it demeaning to have to come all this way?"

No response. But I'm pretty sure I'm getting to her. And let's be fair, among my few talents, I do have one skill which I'm unrivaled at: pissing off people*.

*I might not be a world champion or anything, but I'm probably at least a state or national champion when it comes to authority figures. It's not just being a jerk or stupid; you have to be willfully annoying. It's an art and I'm a connoisseur.

"So what does she want? Can you give me a preview? A hint? Or is it meant to be a surprise?"

Ressa looks over at me with clear annoyance. She seems to consider a range of options, and then indicates the table with the covered cloth.

"Lady Reinhart has sent provisions in case you are hungry. Please avail yourself."

Translated, what she really means is 'eat something and shut up'. I pull back the cloth and find a rather impressive spread of food. Cheese, meats—even wine! I'm tempted, but I'd be an idiot if I actually had some.

Right? I'm tempted, but I wonder if it's spiked with something to make me more truthful. Then again, couldn't Magnolia just have her servants restrain me and pour the truth serum down my throat if she wanted?

Even so, I'm not hungry and I'd rather just annoy Ressa.

"Any idea how long this trip is going to take?"

No response. I smile a bit; I'm enjoying this.

"No? What about games? It's sort of boring just sitting here. Do you have anything fun to do?"

Ressa's eye is twitching again. I grin wider. She looks up, and speaks briefly.

"Would you like me to hit you?"

I...pause. My instinct is to goad her, but Ressa's eyes are very serious. And as I've noted, she's not exactly one to shy away even when outnumbered. I could probably beat her in a fight—but why would Magnolia send her by herself if she was incapable of defending herself or subduing me?

As all that flashes through my head I remain quiet. Ressa holds my gaze for one more second and then nods.

"In that case, be silent."

And then she goes back to staring out the window.

Well.

Um.

I don't think I've ever been—

Huh.

Back home, back in my world when I was younger I got that threat once or twice, when I'd exhausted every other possible response from the adults I was needling. My response back then was 'try it', and if they did I was ready. But here, even with martial arts which I've admittedly been neglecting to practice, I'm at the bottom of a very tall totem pole in terms of fighting ability.

I stare at Ressa. She wouldn't—

Yeah, she would. Crap. What do I do now?

It takes me exactly five minutes to figure out what to do. Ressa looks up sharply as I open the carriage door.

"*What are you doing?*"

"I'm going up front. I think I'll like the view up there."

As I open the door, wind *howls* into the carriage. I jerk back—I'd forgotten how fast we're going! Flying snow blows in and I see the world whirling past, impossibly fast. But hell, I can see Reynold up ahead and if I climb...it would be instant death if I fell out.

Ressa watches me as I hesitate at the door. For a second I wonder if she'll yank me inside, but then she turns and calls.

"Reynold. Slow the coach."

There's a little window he can hear us through. The [Butler] immediately slows the coach. I wait until it's at a stop and then hop out. Ressa stares at me impassively as I walk up to the front and jump up next to the astonished [Butler].

"I'm sitting up here."

He just stares at me before he nods.

"Very good, Miss."

He pulls at a bunch of reins tied to the ghostly horses and the carriage begins to move again. I hear the door *click* shut behind me, and wonder why Ressa let me get up front. Maybe she just doesn't want to deal with me. That makes sense.

Meanwhile, I instantly regret my choice as the carriage picks up speed again. It's not the snow buffeting me that gets me down—the magic coach actually seems to deflect the snow particles. More magic, I guess, and a flying pebble or stick could probably kill the driver.

But it's still frickin' *cold*. And I'm not moving and Erin's soup has worn off. I'm shivering, but I refuse Reynold's offer of a coat. Instead, I just sit up front and let my body get used to the low temperatures. And as the carriage continues to pick up speed, even the freezing weather is banished from my mind by the *speed*.

I've been in cars. Hell, I've driven them pretty damn fast and gotten arrested for it. But this—this is totally different.

Consider, a car moves up to...eighty? Ninety miles per hour? Maybe a hundred if you were insane, but that's pretty much the upper limit outside of race cars. And even open-roof cars have a windshield and a good bit of car in front of the driver. But this—

This is something else.

The wind blows by my face, a tempest of snow and air. The landscape flashes by impossibly fast in my face, and I see all of it, not just the narrow view from the windshield. I'm staring, and I know my jaw is open.

This is life in the fastest lane. This is the sight every runner chases, but more than any normal person could imagine. Maybe Val and Hawk see this as they run. But this is a first for me. I look out, and see a mile flash by in moments. I see people flick by, small shapes on a road. We're off road—

surging smoothly up and down a hill, almost as if we're anchored to the ground.

It's so beautiful. It's wild and quick and magical. And as if that thought calls her, I see a flicker of blue flying out of the white landscape. Ivolethe laughs and flies next to us, flying next to the coach as if she's coasting on a breeze.

"Ivolethe?"

My words are snatched away by the wind, but Reynold hears them. The [Butler] glances at me and I shake my head. The faerie hears me too; she flies closer and speaks in a little voice audible even over the howling winds.

"Look, Ryoka! Look! This is what you need to see!"

"What?"

The faerie flies closer, next to me and points. She laughs as a flurry of snow engulfs her and then flies out of it, trailing vapor, a blue spark of color amidst the gale.

"The wind! Can ye see it? The wind blows! We run with it!"

She flies out, skimming across the land in front of us. She darts up and around, catching a current moving so fast that it speeds her past the carriage. Then she's zooming behind us, flying up, low, around, like azure lightning.

I follow her, entranced, seeing her shape, the sole constant in a world lost to the blur. And as she flies about, following some unseen path, I glimpse something. It's faint; it's like a trail in the air itself. It doesn't have color; rather, it's like a ripple, just like heat makes the air shimmer across the ground. I see it flex ahead of Ivolethe and accordingly she flies up and down and then spins away.

"I see it!"

Reynold jumps in his seat as I half-stand and scream at Ivolethe. She does a double-take in the air and flies towards me.

"Truly!"

"Yes! I see—"

I hesitate. The trail is gone. I squint at where it was, and then look at Ivolethe.

“It was there. I’m sure of it.”

The small faerie grins at me, delighted.

“I believe ye. This is the first step. If you saw that then—”

“You think I can do it again?”

“Miss?”

A voice interrupts Ivolethe’s reply. I look over and see Reynold staring at me, eyes wide.

“What?”

“Are you, ah, speaking to me?”

“What? No. Of course not. I’m speaking to—”

I pause and stare at Ivolethe. I glance back at Reynold and realize that he can’t see the Frost Faerie, or if he can, she’s only a faint blur. Ah.

“Um. I’m speaking to myself. Don’t mind me.”

“Yes, Miss.”

Slowly, I sit back down. Ivolethe grins at me.

“Are ye scaring the poor mortal?”

“Probably.”

I glance over at Reynold. He’s hunching over in his seat, pretending he can’t hear me. His [Butler]’s façade is a bit ragged as he studiously ignores my one-sided conversation, at least from his perspective.

Ivolethe shrugs, as if she couldn’t care less about Reynold. Which is probably true. She points to the whirling scenery and grins.

“Yon contraption is quite a thing! It moves almost as fast as ye did when you drank the magic brew.”

“When? Oh, you mean in the castle. Do you think I could ever learn to run this fast?”

The faerie considers this and shrugs as she props her chin on her hand. She sits on the air next to me.

“Perhaps. But not at first. I can sense the magic in this thing; it is rough, but there is an art to it. Does the lady who sends her servants to you have much wealth like this?”

“A lot. I don’t know how much, but she’s one of the wealthiest and most powerful individuals on the continent.”

That makes me worried again, but having Ivolethe around dispels a lot of my fears. The faerie nods seriously.

“Then perhaps a bit of respect is in order. The lords and ladies of the land were always touchy and prideful, even to the King of Knights.”

“King Arthur?”

“Aye.”

Ivolethe smiles and points. I turn my head and see Reynold is actually edging away from me on the front of the carriage. That makes me smile too. I wonder if I should explain to him what’s going on—but nah.

The faerie pauses as she seems to glance at the horizon ahead of us. She frowns at me.

“There is much moving in the world this time. Much happens even as ye ride about.”

“Oh? Like what?”

“Like the children. They are marching.”

“The...children? Who?”

“The youngest. The ones with small ears and crimson eyes. They burnt a city, did they not? And they fight amongst themselves. They are moving about in the snow.”

She means Goblins. The children? The youngest? I frown at Ivolethe, but decide to pursue their movements before I ask about the other bit.

“What do you mean they’re moving? Moving where?”

“Everywhere. They run about in their hundreds, coming north from south. A vast army sits below the pass—you have seen them once.”

The Goblin Lord. I shiver. Ivolethe nods, and then points ahead of us.

“But another army—smaller, but thousands strong—lies ahead. They march north as well. Fleeing their own kind.”

“What? Where?”

I sit up in the carriage, heart pounding. Ivolethe nods at Reynold.

“Yon clueless fool is about to drive you straight into the center of them.”

For a second I just stare at Ivolethe in horror. She grins at me, exposing a mouth full of sharp teeth. Then she flies up and away.

Instantly, I turn in my seat.

“Driver, turn the coach around!”

Reynold stares at me. He looks around, and then points to himself.

“D-do you mean me, Miss—?”

“Stop the carriage! We’re about to run into Goblins!”

“Goblins?”

He just stares at me incredulously. I see a large hill approaching, and curse. I reach for the reins. Instinctively Reynold pulls away.

“Please don’t, Miss Ryoka. I can’t let you—”

“What is going on?”

Then a panel slides open behind us. I see Ressa’s impatient glare as she looks at us. There’s no time to explain. I try to grab the reins. Reynold pulls away, Ressa shouts. The carriage swerves as we crest the hill—

And then there are Goblins. They march in a vast column across the valley in the snow, trampling slush into mud as they walk a hundred abreast. I see Hobs, dragging weapons in the snow, massive, dwarfing the smaller Goblins that run before them.

Children, what look like pregnant mothers and of course, warriors walk in some semblance of order, carrying packs, lugging improvised sleds—

some are even herding horses, mules and other pack animals! It's the most hodge-podge collection of equipment I've ever seen. And at the head of that group is a detachment of Carn Wolves. Ridden by Goblins.

My heart stops. The sudden surge of fear and panic makes the world slow as the carriage shoots over the hill and directly into the mass of the Goblins. I turn my head and see Reynold frantically pull the reins left. The carriage immediately turns, but it's too late.

Goblins, hearing the sound of the carriage and the shower of snow, turn and cry out as we speed past the column. I hear their high-pitched screams, and then horn calls.

Instantly, the group of wolf riders at the head of the column turns. They run towards us and I shout.

"Take us away!"

Reynold desperately pulls, and the carriage turns. But although we're already speeding away, the Goblins are *everywhere*. And this particular bunch is smart, because the wolf riders are already running to cut us off. We must have passed some scouts because they come from behind us, trying to run us down.

I see a tall Hobgoblin on a Carn Wolf running at us, shouting as more riders run with him. The main column of Goblins is in panic—warriors are surging towards us en masse as the children and other Goblins try to run back.

"What should we do?"

Reynold shouts in fear as the wolves box us in. He's trying to pull us away, but the wolves are *everywhere*.

"Go through them!"

I point at a few wolf riders and pray like hell the carriage can take a hit. Reynold hesitates—

And then I feel a hand grab the edge of the carriage. I jerk, but it's no Goblin. Ressa pulls herself up as the carriage speeds along and shouts a word.

"*[Invisibility Field]!*"

Instantly, the world around us goes dark. I see runes on the carriage glowing, and the Goblins around us cry out, their eyes tracking the air where we were. I look around. Are we invisible? I can't tell, but we must be. It's as if someone's put sunglasses on the world.

"That way."

Ressa points and Reynold immediately turns the carriage, making a break for an opening in the ranks of Goblins and wolfriders. After a moment I hear more shouting, and look back to see pursuit has resumed. How...?

“The snow! They can see it!”

I shout and Ressa nods. The Goblins can indeed see the geysering snow from the carriage’s passage and they follow that. But the moment of hesitation has given us an opportunity. If we can just get ahead of them the carriage will easily outdistance their riders—

As we pass by more Goblins, I see something strange. A knot of huge Hobgoblins is dead ahead of us, and they’re turning, weapons raised and ready for us. Reynold takes us right past them, but then I spot something odd. In the center of the armed group of elites, a small Goblin is riding a wolf. And she has something in her hands. She raises a black crossbow, almost as big as she is, and points it at us. She can’t see us, surely. But she knows where we are. And she’s aiming—I shout.

“*Down!*”

The carriage swerves as I pull Reynold down and I see Ressa blur beside me. The crossbow bolt streaks towards the side of the carriage and *shatters* as it touches us. The bolt doesn’t break the magically-reinforced sides of the carriage—

But it does end the spell. The world goes bright again and I realize we’re visible. The Goblins shout and Reynold desperately flaps the reins to move us faster. I glance back at the Goblin with the crossbow—

And recognize her. Rags meets my shocked gaze for one second, and I see her own eyes widening. And then we’re past her in a blur of snow.

“We’re almost away, Miss Ressa!”

Reynold shouts in relief as the Goblins fall away behind us. Then he shouts in alarm as someone runs ahead of us. The tall Hobgoblin is streaking at us from the side, on a direct collision course as he rides his massive Carn Wolf. I hear Ressa mutter something from my side. I’m scrabbling at my belt for a potion, one of the bags—anything. But I’m too slow, and the tall Hobgoblin’s mouth is open in a roar as he holds a crimson sword over his head—

On the carriage beside me, Ressa stands up. Her hand *blurs*, and something flashes at the Hobgoblin. He jerks, and his sword deflects a flying object with a *ringing* sound. Ressa’s hands move again and the Hob

snarls and jerks his reins. The Carn Wolf dodges away as five more black blurs fly at him. He strikes down each one, but while he does the carriage flies on. In a second we're past him, and his howl of fury confirms that we are safe.

Then we're gone. The Goblins racing after us stop as they become distant figures, and then just blips on the horizon. We race on through the snow, once again lost in a void of silence.

The three of us just sit on the front of the carriage, breathing hard. At least, Reynold and I am. Ressa is still sitting on the edge, still gripping the open door she came out of. Reynold's hands are white on the reins and I'm wondering if I'm going to have a heart attack.

Gods. What just happened? Goblins, obviously. But so many? Where are they going? Was that *Rags*, Erin's little friend!? And the other Hob—I could have sworn he was the one at the inn! What's going on?

And Ressa? My head turns and I stare at her. She returns my look impassively.

"We're safe now."

That's all she says. Slowly, she begins to pull herself back into the carriage, ignoring the wind ripping at her maid's uniform. I call out to her.

"Wait! What was that?"

She just stares at me. And shrugs.

"My orders were to keep you safe."

I point to her with a trembling hand. It was just a blur—hell, all of that was a blur. But I saw what she threw at the Hobgoblin.

"That was a *throwing star*. Are you—?"

Ressa slams the door to the carriage without a second word. I stare at the door. Oh my god. That can't be true, can it? Is she a ninja mai—

Nah. I sit back with the [Butler] and shake my head. I'm going nuts. This entire thing is nuts. I'm nuts, I want to eat nuts—I'm shaking—

So is poor Reynold. His face is pale, although he still looks pretty damn composed for someone who just drove us through a Goblin army. More props to him, I guess. If this is how all British people are, no wonder they didn't crack when they were getting the shit bombed out of them during World War II.

I'm generalizing. And panicking. I take a few more breaths of cold air to still my beating heart. That was—jeez.

After a minute I rap on the little window that connects us with the coach with a trembling hand. It doesn't open.

"Hey. You in there. Pass us a bottle, will you?"

I shout it at Ressa and hear no response. But after a moment, the window slides open and one of the bottles of wine is handed through, bottom-first.

I pop the cork after six tries, and then drink from the top. It's probably high-grade stuff I gulp down; I don't even taste it. After I down a third of the bottle I nudge Reynold. He jumps and the carriage swerves; when he sees the bottle, he gratefully accepts it and drinks from it without a word.

We just sit in silence for a while, passing the bottle back and forth. After we finish it, I throw the bottle into the snow, ignoring every instinct in my body that tells me not to litter, and I get Ressa to pass us another one.

Reynold drinks, I drink. We stare at the landscape, and I look at the side of the carriage. The crossbow bolt didn't even scratch the paintwork. God.

I want this carriage.

After I'm feeling a bit warmer and the cold sweat has mainly evaporated, I glance at Reynold. He's got a bit of a flush as well. He's just a [Butler], wearing a light grey jacket over his dark clothing. He's holding the reins steady, guiding the magic horses forward.

"Is it always like this?"

He shudders, and shakes his head for a second before changing his mind and nodding weakly.

"Sometimes. On bad days."

"Jeez."

I sit back, and stare ahead. The world is white. It rushes past me with a roaring sound made faint by the carriage's magic. I sigh, and look ahead. My friends and Goblins lie behind. And in the distance I see a faint shape on the horizon. Dark buildings, rising out of the ground as the light in the sky fades to nothing.

Invisil, the City of Adventurers, awaits. And after that—
Lady Magnolia.

3.11 E

Day 31

I wake up when I hear the crying. It isn't Durene. She sleeps beside me, or rather, slightly apart from me on the floor of her cottage. Even though we're close, we sleep a bit apart. Durene sometimes rolls over in her sleep, and I have no desire to be squished like a bug twice. Especially because she's so hard to wake up when she's in a deep sleep.

Cautiously, quietly, I roll out of my side of the bed, trying not to wake Durene. She needs her sleep, and if she knows I'm awake she'll fuss over me and be too anxious to rest. I shiver as my shoulder touches the cold floor of Durene's cottage. I briskly get up and grope around for my clothing, locating the undergarments and over garments I placed next to my head when I slept.

It's harder than I'd like; I keep finding what I think is a coat and instead pulling up part of the warm blanket Durene and I were sharing. Part of the issue is that I can't tell where clothing stops and Durene's bed begins.

My friend and host Durene doesn't have a proper bed; just a mattress made of soft blankets and pillows. I can understand why; she'd probably break any raised surface with her weight, and even a king-sized bed wouldn't exactly be that big for her. Durene's not a giant, but she *is* half-Troll, and that means she's easily six foot six, or maybe even taller. I can only guess; I'm just over six foot myself, so I have to use that as a reference when measuring her.

Fully dressed but sock-less, I shiver as I pad around the room. Still cold, even with multiple layers. I feel at one of the windows and touch a wooden shutter, cold and frozen. Right. Durene has no glass.

But I don't need to go outside to feel the cold emanating from the window. And the lovely little fire Durene made last night has gone out, even the embers. Winter is truly and deeply upon us.

Normally I wouldn't care. I'd wake up later, and help Durene make breakfast. But today is different. I pause as I hunt for a sock and raise my head.

"There it is again."

I whisper the words. Someone is crying. Not someone, actually. Something. I can tell it's no person out there, but something animal. It's shrieking. I think it's a bird, but it sounds far different from any bird call I've heard back home. Far more anxious and...desperate.

Yes, a bird. But then, maybe I'm being too hasty here. I think it's a bird, but given that I'm in a fantasy world, couldn't it well be a bird person? Do they exist? I'll have to ask Durene when she wakes up.

Regardless, this creature's definitely in some distress to be broadcasting so loudly. I'll be the first to admit I'm more sensitive to sounds than Durene, but this bird got me up even in the middle of my sleep. And it's odd, but I have a very strong compulsion to go to it. And I even know where this...bird...is.

"Very odd."

My socks are on, and my comfortable shoes are laced. I pause with my hand on the door, wondering what I'm doing. It's snowy outside, and even though I have my walking cane in one hand, I know from experience how easy it is to get lost by myself.

But the creature calls out again, and I push open the door and walk outside before I can stop myself. After all, I can just retrace my steps if I go a short ways. It's not that far—and I can shout for Durene.

All excuses, I know. But I have to follow this feeling. And so I silently close the door so as not to wake Durene and walk out into the snow.

It's deep. I nearly stumble as I find it's a foot deep. Jeez, winter here is *not* fun. And Durene's told me it can snow far more before the season is over. I poke at the snow in front of me, but my cane's no good in this weather. I make a disgusted noise, but still—

"A rock straight ahead?"

No. It's just my imagination. But a few cautious steps forward and my cane pokes into the snow and finds—

A rock. Yes, a *rock*. Either that or some kind of fossilized vegetable. Nah, it's a rock. But how did I know it was there?

Half a dozen explanations pop into my head, but I have no time to stop and consider them. The bird cries out again, and this time I can tell it's from the ground, a little bit ahead of me and to the left, on the edge of the forest surrounding the cottage.

"Yes, yes. I'm coming."

No longer walking with my cane, I stride across the snowy ground with more confidence than I've felt in a long time. I know I'm walking straight through Durene's frozen-over garden, and I also know what spots are slippery and even that she's sown several crops for next year that are hibernating under the ice—and that there's a cluster of turnips she forgot to pull up. I skirt her fence, walk towards a tree, and stop.

How did I just *do* that? It wasn't sight—I've never seen in my life, but I know you'd use your eyes for that and I had mine shut the entire time. But I knew where everything was. Yet here I stop, at the edge of where my... perception of the landscape fades away. Yes, it's as if there's a large circle around Durene's cottage I can sense, and then just emptiness past that.

And at the base of one tree, I can sense anxious movement, faint life. And my ears confirm that as I hear the creature cry out in alarm as I approach.

"What's this, now?"

Broken branch. Twigs, bird poo, bones...the remains of a nest. And on the ground—

I reach out and something *pecks* at my hand. I yelp and draw my hand back, and the fledgling bird cries out again, calling for its parents. But if it had parents, it wouldn't be alone. So, shivering, I come to a quick decision.

"None of that, now."

The bird cries out in alarm and tries to get away, but it's much too weak and cold. I briskly scoop it up and ignore its struggling. The bird pecks at me again, but this time he only gets my gloves. I walk back to Durene's cottage, thinking hard all the while.

Birds fallen from nest? Doubtless. What happens to birds when that happens? I know the best thing to do is to put it back in the nest, but what if the parent is gone? Maybe it's just independent?

No—I feel gently at the bird as it squawks anxiously again and amend my opinion. I don't feel any feathers, only fuzz. This is no fledgling, a semi-adult bird. It's a baby chick, or whatever the correct term is. I'm no bird watcher.

And two more things I note: the bird is quite big for a baby. And it's also very cold. It's shivering; how long was it out in the snow? I hurry up and push into the cottage.

A low growling sound makes the bird in my hands shut up instantly. I smile as I hear Durene snoring; she didn't even notice me come back in.

Well, she might have to wake up soon regardless.

First things first. I don't bother hunting for anything; I just turn and grab a bowl out of Durene's shelves. Once again, I know exactly which one will fit the bird, and in another second I've wrapped it gently in a towel, both to warm it and prevent it from escaping. The chick is trembling. No doubt it thinks I'm going to eat it.

Well, food is a good idea, both for me and it. I sense around, and find some bread. I slice some, again, with more confidence than I'd ever have normally, and offer some crumbled bits to the bird. It shies away from my hand, and then I feel a cautious *peck* at my bare skin. The bird finds a crumb, seems to taste it, and then spits the wet stuff back onto my hand.

"Huh?"

That's odd. Don't all birds like bread? I frown and try again. But this time the bird just *squawks* a bit as I try to push the crumbs at it, and it doesn't touch them even when I leave some crumbs in the bowl for it.

"Drat. What kind of bird do you call yourself?"

I grumble at the bird as I move onto my alternate plan: getting this place warmed up. Durene's stacked firewood in a corner, but up till this point I'd let her make the fire. I like to think I'm quite capable, but it really is a bad idea to have the blind guy messing around with flames.

But once again, I can quite definitely tell where things are, and even if I can't see the position of the fireplace, I know where it is. Almost like...a memory? Or a fact. Either way, my hands are steady as I strike the flint and steel repeatedly and eventually manage to get some kindling to light.

"Fire, check."

What's next? I feed the flames a bit and fan them to make them brighter, or however it is that's supposed to work. I guess if the bird won't eat, I'll get something. There are eggs in a basket Durene brought from the village, but I'd feel guilty eating them right at this moment. How about...hm?

Sausage?

Oh yes, there's half a dried sausage in Durene's pantry. I know she's been saving it for a special occasion; meat is a luxury for her. I hesitate as I bring it out. Maybe just a bit? Fried sausage would be a *treat*, but can I...?

The chick suddenly squawks and kicks up a racket as I bring the sausage past it. I frown, stop, and clumsily tear off a bit of meat.

"You want this? Really?"

I know baby birds eat meat. I mean, they eat bugs. But I thought they liked seeds and plants more than—you know what? I'm not going to argue with the facts, especially when one fact is trying to tear the bit of meat out of my fingers.

The chick greedily devours the first bit of meat I feed it, then the next. Bemused, I find a knife and slice up a good portion of the sausage into bite-sized morsels to feed the chick. It scarfs the pieces down—so quickly and so fast that I'm worried I'll overfeed it and make it sick! I stop after I've given it nearly a quarter of the sausage, but then the chick just cries out for more!

"Shush, you!"

It doesn't listen to me. What a sound it makes! It's more like a whistle than a cry. It sounds nothing like the twittering sparrows and occasional duck that will wander by my parent's home. But it does sound familiar...

"Huh? Wuzzis?"

I lightly nudge the squalling chick with a knuckle.

"And now you've woken Durene. Good job, you."

"Laken? What's going on? Why are you awake and—*what's that?*"

I turn and smile at Durene. Her confused voice and the way she clumsily makes her way over to me—these are the things that are now familiar to me. Funny, but after a month of living in her company I know her so well.

"Good morning, Durene. Sorry to wake you, but we have a guest."

"Is that a bird? And...my sausage?"

Her voice is dismayed, but after a round of explanations she's only too willing to help me make breakfast and play detective. The first thing she does is exclaim over the way I'm able to help her prepare today's meal: a soup made of onions, leeks, peas, and cabbage. Pottage, in fact. It's seasoned heavily with dried thyme and some garlic and it tastes not bad at all. True, it's a poor meal to live on each day, but I'm happy enough eating it.

"How can you tell where everything is?"

Durene is bewildered as I nimbly pour soup into a bowl and bring it to the table, next to the restless chick. I shake my head, smiling fit to burst.

"I have no idea. It must be from my Class!"

"But how? I thought an [Emperor] ruled. Why can they see things? Without their eyes, I mean."

“It’s not exactly the same.”

Cautiously, I spoon the hot soup into my mouth and think as I chew.

“It’s gotta be—I think we added too much thyme, Durene—it must be due to the fact that this is part of my domain. That is to say. My demesne.”

“Your—what?”

“Demesne. It’s another word for, well, land owned by someone. I know this is your cottage, Durene, but I claimed it when I became an [Emperor].”

“I know that. And I’m happy to let you, uh, have it.”

“Thank you. But that means I own every part of the land, not just the cottage. The ground, the sky—that must be why I can sense where to go. Because it is mine.”

“Oh.”

My friend’s voice is a sigh of wonder. A loud sigh, which makes the chick on the table next to me chirp in alarm. I sit up at the odd cry and frown again, tickled by that same thought.

“This is one weird bird, though. I can feel it, but I’m afraid that even with my new...abilities...I can’t really tell what it is. Durene, what does it look like?”

I hear Durene get up anxiously and pace around the chick. She comes nearer to me and apparently bends over, because the chick pecks her nose.

“Ow!”

“Careful. It’s pretty violent for a baby. It *is* a baby, right?”

“It looks like it. It’s one week—no, maybe two weeks old? But it’s really big...I thought it was a fledgling at first, but like you said, it has no feathers.”

“A big bird...”

Sesame Street? No, focus, Laken. But now that I think of it, there might actually be land bound birds as tall as Big Bird in this world. Now *there’s* a terrifying thought.

“What else do you see?”

“Um. Well—it’s got a weird color. Sort of—well, dark grey. Almost greenish.”

“Green fuzz?”

Doesn’t mean much to me, although I don’t know any green birds. But chicks don’t look anything like their adult forms.

“Well, I found it on the ground. I think the nest it was in fell off the branch. Maybe the parent’s still around and we can return it.”

I get up and Durene and I leave the chick behind to go investigate the spot where I found it. I feel...amazingly happy to be able to walk that short distance without my cane. There's no trepidation, no sense of unease as I walk. I know where everything is, and I don't have to hesitate.

Thank you. I don't know who or what brought me here, but just for a little while longer, can you let me feel like a—a normal person? Is this what it feels like? To walk and know that the ground is *there* and I am *here*?

Then I come up to that blank spot where the world ends, and Durene gasps as she sees the nest.

"Bones! Look at all the tiny bones, Laken! And over there—oh no."

She sees something past the spot I can sense and walks over. I wait, trying to piece together my own sensory inputs. I can tell there are bones in the nest, but I didn't focus on the size until now. There's still a difference between what Durene sees and what I comprehend.

"What is it?"

"I...found the parent, Laken. It—she? She's dead."

Durene comes back, holding a dead bird in her hands. I blink as it comes into my zone and I register the *size* of the bird. It's almost a third as tall as I am!

"That's no sparrow."

"No."

Half-troll she might be, but Durene has a heart that weeps for everything. She sounds upset as she tells me how it died.

"It must have died of the cold. See here—oh, sorry Laken. It was fighting something, but it got hurt bad. It was bleeding, and it must have lost all its warmth when it got cold."

"I get it."

I sigh as Durene and I pause, unexpectedly sad over the death of this bird. I'm about to ask if we should bury it, when I sense Durene plucking feathers off the corpse.

"...What are you doing?"

"Oh—I thought we could eat it later. It's still cold and nothing's been chewing on it, so—"

Oh. Ah. Hm. Well, I've heard of people eating road kill, and at least the bird was well-preserved. Maybe I'll let Durene have it, although I could use some meat myself...

“Okay, let’s put that aside for now. What about the nest? You say there are bones here, right? Little ones?”

“That’s right. They’re very small, but...I don’t know how any predator would have eaten the others and left the chick you found alive.”

“No, it wouldn’t do that.”

My mind jumps to an unfortunate conclusion. I bent down and touch at the bones with one gloveless hand. Yup. They’re picked clean.

“A predator didn’t kill the other babies. The chick did. It ate its brothers and sisters to survive.”

An unhappy sound. Durene didn’t want to come to that conclusion, but it’s the only one that makes sense. I straighten and sigh.

“Nature at its best. But I think I have a good idea who this mystery bird is. It’s an eagle, isn’t it?”

“I think so. It could be a hawk—I’m not a [Hunter] so I can’t tell the difference. But it looks like one of the birds that sometimes tries to swoop down and carry off a lamb, baby piglets, and so on.”

“Carry off lambs? Seriously?”

I’d heard stories of eagles trying to carry off kids, but I thought that was just a popular myth. But Durene sounds serious.

“Oh yes. [Herders] and [Farmers] have to be careful. An eagle can swoop down and fly away with a lamb in seconds if they don’t keep an eye out. Normally we try to get people with bows to shoot the eagle first, but it’s hard unless someone’s got a high level.”

“Well, this baby eagle—I think they’re called eaglets, actually— isn’t going to be carrying off anything anytime soon. I think now’s the moment when we make a choice, Durene.”

“About what?”

She sounds apprehensive. I make a rueful expression, or what I’ve been told is rueful.

“About whether we keep it or not.”

“Do you mean—we’d throw it out in the cold?”

She sounds horrified. I guess I’ve got my answer. We walk back to her cottage. Durene pauses to bury the dead bird in the snow rather than bring it inside and show the chick.

“I’m just thinking about the problems. A baby eagle needs attention, food—the attention bit’s not so hard, but I’m pretty sure it only eats meat.”

“Oh.”

“Oh indeed.”

Here’s why this is a problem in this world. In mine, the biggest obstacle would be getting a permit to raise a baby eagle—they’re considered illegal to own in the United States, and I suspect other countries wouldn’t be too hot on them as a pet either. Housing would be another problem I guess, and training—

But here, meat is the issue. There’s not exactly a supermarket around here, and Durene’s not rich. I am, but Riverfarm isn’t, so I don’t know how far the gold coins I dug up would go down there anyways.

“I think we should take care of him.”

Durene’s voice interrupts me. I can tell she’s practically wringing her hands, and her voice is anxious.

“If we need to, I can get meat. I could try setting a trap or hunting. And I—I have pigs!”

It’s funny how she cares more for a chick I found than the pigs she’s raised for years. Then again, she must have to force herself to look at the pigs as food. I nod as I pick up the upset little bird and it pecks at my hands.

“Okay then. Hopefully it won’t come to that.”

“Do you really think we’ll be able to raise him?”

There’s a glimmer of hope in her tone. As it so often happens, I realize that this is something Durene might have dreamed about but could never realize. A pet. It sounds so simple, but for her, it might just have been a dream.

“We can try. But I have to warn you, Durene. The chick might die no matter what we do.”

“Oh no.”

Durene already sounds heartbroken as she hovers around the bird in my hands. I find her arm with a hand and pat it gently. But I don’t give her false hope. I’m under no illusions; I don’t know how to raise birds, and this young one was born too late. Or maybe birds in this world can’t tell when winter is about to arrive thanks to those...Winter Sprites, and so they can only hope.

With those thoughts in mind, I find myself constructing a more permanent nest for the chick. And that’s with the understanding that this nest isn’t going to be reused; the chick has already pooped quite extensively in Durene’s bowl.

“It should probably be pretty big. Yes—that’s about right.”

I smile to myself as Durene fusses over the chick, holding it gently and exclaiming as it pecks at her hands.

“Does it...have a name?”

“Not yet. Would you like to name it, Durene?”

“Oh—I couldn’t. Why don’t you, Laken? You found it, anyways.”

I nod and take the chick from Durene, it struggles a bit in my grip, but I have a good hold over its growing wings. I stare down at it and think for a second. And perhaps it’s another bit of whimsy, but I decide that if I’m going to take care of this bird, I might as well do it properly.

Straightening my back, I place the chick on the new nest, and put my hand solemnly on its head. It doesn’t move about much; I make my voice deeper as I speak to Durene and the world at large.

“It’s not often that I find a baby bird lying on the ground. But since you’re here and your mother—or father—is gone, it falls to me to take care of you. You—chick.”

The little bird pecks at the bottom of my hand.

“Stop that.”

Durene giggles. I smile, and think for a moment.

“Well then, I think I’ll name you Frostwing, because that sounds quite appropriate for a bird in a fantasy world. It sounds a bit silly, but maybe you’ll grow into it. And I accept you into my small empire as one of my loyal, if noisy, subjects.”

The bird goes still for a second, and then I sense it rustling under my hand. Durene makes cooing sounds of delight.

“Aw! It’s grooming itself, Laken!”

“I’ll take that as a ‘yes’. Okay, let’s finish this nest and figure out where it’s going to sleep. I don’t want it wandering off during the night.”

“Okay!”

And there we have it. Another little addition to the cottage. I’m not sure if I regret it; little Frostwing pecks at my fingers and it eats and defecates a bit too much for my comfort. It has a very sharp, curved beak. Plus, it has a rather shrill cry that can get on the nerves—

And yet, I can’t see any other way this encounter could have gone. Would I have left it there to die? No. There’s no way I would have. And I have to wonder as I go to sleep, Frostwing resting in its new nest in the kitchen. I have to wonder if it was like that for Durene with me. Perhaps I

was a little bird she found in the forest. The thought makes me smile as I close my eyes and sleep.

[Emperor Level 5!]

[Beast Tamer Obtained!]

[Beast Tamer Level 1!]

[Skill – Lesser Bond: Frostwing obtained!]

“...Oh you have got to be kidding me.”

Day 32

Why is leveling up so easy? No, before that, why is gaining a new class so easy?

This is the thought that circles around in my head, nudging my brain every once in a while. I don't really have the brain cells to allocate to the issue though; I'm so sleep deprived that I can barely think straight.

It's been a long night, and a longer morning. Durene is asleep, and I'm on bird-feeding duty. Again. As it turns out, Frostwing, the noisy little eaglet, apparently needs to be fed on an hourly basis. Or at least that's how it felt last night. And since Durene isn't as nimble as I am, it fell to me to get out of the warm, comfortable bed and feed the squalling creature while avoiding its sharp beak.

Do I regret all of this? Yes and no. The class helps. It really does. Because now I can wonder—what does 'lesser bond' mean? What's the benefit of this class? Will it just aid me in raising Frostwing? Or are there applicable benefits?

Right now the only benefit I can feel is knowing how much to feed Frostwing. It's like intuition—I can tell if the bird needs another morsel, or if feeding it—her too much would result in her puking up her meal. That's valuable info, as is her gender.

I can't tell with my [Emperor] senses, and I'm not about to go probing with my fingers. But Durene checked, and this bird is indeed a female one. Good for her.

But back to my class. I get the [Beast Tamer] class. It only makes sense that I'd get it. But why did I level up as an [Emperor]? Let's think about

that.

I poke Frostwing as she tears at a bit of meat. She pecks my finger. I rub at an eye and frown.

Intent. Intent and purpose. I was fully committed to keeping the eaglet—Frostwing alive. Not only that; I fulfilled some criteria for the [Emperor] class. It makes sense that gaining exp for an [Emperor] would involve growing my kingdom and recruiting new subjects somehow.

But seriously? One baby eagle is worth a level in [Emperor]? No—no, wait a second. Maybe it's not just numbers, but something else. Durene was my first vassal, but she came with the class. This is the first time I've declared my sovereignty over another being, and after I'd rescued them from death within my sovereign territory, no less.

That's the only explanation I can come up with. How confusing. If only there were an instruction manual, or a wiki page or something I could use. But assuming this is a game, or something similar, the fun would be in finding how the rules work. And exploiting any secrets you can find.

Poke. Peck. Poke. Peck.

I keep baiting Frostwing, letting her strike at my finger and pulling it away before she can tag me. It's, well, pretty fun, although getting pecked isn't. But it must be fun, because before I know it, Durene's awake.

"Laken! Is your finger bleeding?"

"So it is. I guess I must have got lost in playing."

"For how *long*?"

"I'm not sure. Hours? I fed her twice."

"*Twice?*"

I'm not good with sleep deprivation. Not that I think anyone's exactly proficient in that area. Once I'm more awake and I've had a cup of tea—and what I wouldn't give for an espresso—Durene and I get about the business of business. We don't always stay in the cottage, although it's a tempting option in this cold weather.

Our goal for today is actually quite simple: in lieu of the practically gone sausage, Durene and I have to find something for Frostwing to eat. She doesn't want to butcher one of her pigs and I can't blame her. They're not fully grown yet, and it would be a terrible waste, even if she and I eat some of it.

Plus, I don't quite have the heart for it. What I do have the heart for, and what came to me as I was feeding Frostwing a bit more sausage, was that

my [Emperor] senses can be used for more than just navigation.

“Right here.”

I whisper to Durene as we stand next to a tree trunk. She’s silent for a second.

“Found it. It’s a small hole.”

“Want me to—?”

“No. I’ve got it.”

Durene takes a deep breath, and then I hear her reach into the hole in the tree trunk. There’s alarmed chattering and frantic movement as her hand enters the squirrel’s nest, then—

“Got one.”

I *heard* the crunch. I feel a bit sick, but I know it’s not over. There are—were—three squirrels nesting in the tree that I sensed. Durene grimly catches the other two and swiftly snaps their necks.

“It’s done, Laken. I’ll pull them out if you can hold them—”

“Got it.”

She might not like killing creatures, but she’s efficient when she does. I hold the surprisingly heavy creatures, wincing as I feel their dangling necks.

“I feel bad.”

“...Yeah.”

It was an idea. If I can sense Frostwing, what about other creatures? Turns out I can at least find squirrel dens, if I concentrate. Is this fair? No. But we’re out of meat and Frostwing needs a meal. So this has to be done.

Once we’re finished, Durene and I walk back to the cottage. She actually took the acorns the squirrels had been hoarding as well; they can be ground up. Durene doesn’t waste any food. Then we’re in the kitchen, Frostwing cheeping with excitement. Three squirrels are ready to be skinned in moments, and I have to help with that grisly business. It wouldn’t be right otherwise.

“Um—I—I think we’ve got to—with the head—”

“I’ll do it.”

It’s grisly, and it involves sawing and hacking, neither of us being proficient in preparing animals. Durene is no hunter, and if she does find animals, she generally has someone in the village help her prepare it for a share of the food. She didn’t even manage to bring herself to eat Frostwing’s mother—after some debate we buried her half-plucked corpse just outside the garden.

At least I can't see what I'm doing. Durene assures me that in this case, this is a good thing. Mind you, I don't like the *squishing* and the—rest. But I'm not the one who has to stumble out of the cottage for a breath of fresh air.

"Durene? I think I'm done."

Quietly, Durene takes the fur and other inedible bits outside. I can tell she's burying the pieces. She's a bit snuffly when she comes back in, but determined to put a brave face on it.

"At least Frostwing gets to eat. That's—it's for her."

I nod. The chick is already demanding a bloody piece of meat, and we can freeze the rest although we'll have to watch out for scavengers. Hell, we could probably kill them.

Durene shudders a bit as I put the meat into a bowl. I clean my hands with water after I feed Frostwing and then go over to her.

"Did they bite your hand?"

"A bit. But—it's fine. My skin's tough and I did far worse to them."

She sounds unhappy. And guilty. Carefully, I hold her hands, making sure they're unharmed for myself. Thick skin. But such a terribly soft heart.

"You're a gentle soul."

I kiss Durene gently on the cheek. She blushes—I can feel it. And then of course one thing leads to another. At least Frostwing doesn't interrupt us more than once.

What? It's not like it's hard to figure out what people in this world do in the winter. And Durene and I are new at this. But kissing her I could do forever. I could sit and talk with her long into the night. And I do. Other things happen of course, but sometimes it's just worth sitting by someone you...

Love.

[Beast Tamer Level 2!]

Day 34

It's funny. I've had pets, and it's always flurry and new experiences those first few days. But after a while, even feeding an eaglet bloody pieces of meat you've butchered yourself gets normal.

That's how I find myself sitting in the kitchen, playing poke-peck with Frostwing. I think she could use the exercise, and I myself have already gone for a brisk walk with Durene. But at this time of day I usually stay indoors while she works.

Yes, works. Durene's job doesn't end in the winter of course. In fact, there might even be more to do. She planted a number of crops that could be harvested in the winter, and aside from tending to them, she has to clear out snow every day as well. She also normally takes this time to fix up her cottage, repair any tools, and of course, chop firewood.

With me around I can at least fix her meals and help with some small-time repairs, but my job is mainly looking after the chick. I'm certainly not a [Lumberjack]. Truth be told, neither is Durene, but with her strength it doesn't really matter. I asked her about it at one point; she has an old axe, but she claims she only uses it to hack up the tree when it's felled. As to the felling, she says it's easy.

"I mean, if it's a small tree, I can just kick it or push it over."

...So it sounds simple enough for her. At any rate, Durene gets paid a pittance for supplying Riverfarm village with firewood, so when she's not with me and Frostwing, she's out in the forest. Rather, I make her go. I'm now fully confident in myself thanks to my new Skill, and we can't always be cramped together.

Not that that's necessarily a bad thing.

Anyways it's just me and Frostwing, testing our reflexes. My attention's completely focused on the game, until I feel a...sensation at the back of my mind and get distracted.

As I pull my finger back a bit too slowly, Frostwing hits me with a good peck and pierces my skin. I yelp and I hear what almost sounds like a cheep of apology from her. But I'm not paying attention to the bird. My head turns and I frown.

"Someone's coming."

By the time [Farmer] Prost stops outside the cottage, I'm already waiting for him, a smile on my lips. If he's confused by my intuition, his voice doesn't show any sign of it.

"Mister Laken, I'm glad to see you're well this day."

"I'm glad to meet you as well, Mister Prost. You'll have to tell me if you're well."

A bit cold, I know. But I still remember how I last met the man. I hear a pause, and then a note of uncertainty in Prost's voice.

"I'm well, Mister Laken. Thank you for asking."

"And your wife? How is Yesel doing? And the kids?"

"All well, Mister Laken."

Well, that's enough pleasantries. I nod and smile again, cheerfully. And say nothing else. If he wants anything else he can just say it.

After another moment of uncertainty, Prost gets to the point.

"Not to be interrupting you, Mister Laken, but ah, I was wondering if I could have a word with you. About Durene."

"Another word? Well, I suppose I have no choice but to hear you out. What's wrong with Durene this time?"

"Nothing, sir. It's just, well, I'd like to talk, that's all."

Oh? Talk? I see. I let Prost go on.

"Durene's a good...girl. But she's only a [Farmer], and I understand you're not. She's said as much when she came into the village a day ago. I'd hate to think she was getting involved with someone with other duties later on, if you understand me."

Oh? Is it now 'you're too good for her'? What is with these people? My smile freezes a bit on my face. But I keep silent. Wait. Wait for him to keep going and then smack him in the face.

Metaphorically, of course.

"We, ah, understand—"

Now. I jump in, my voice as smooth as I can make it. Friendly. Open. I put honest confusion into my tone.

"Do excuse me, Mister Prost. I'm afraid I'm a bit off-balance. You see, I thought you were coming here for something else."

"Oh? What's that, Mister Laken?"

"Well, it's just that—and you may call me silly for thinking this—I was under the distinct impression that you were coming here to apologize."

"Apologize...?"

"To Durene. For calling her a monster. Inhuman. A *freak*."

I wish I could see his face. I can only tell the man is standing in front of me, but then I hear him shift in the snow. Uneasily.

"I, ah, regret the other day, Mister Laken. I do. But I only spoke the truth. It needed to be said. And even if Durene was—upset, it don't change

the facts. So I don't think I need to say anything to anyone, if you understand me."

Again I interrupt him. This time I don't even try to keep the undertone of irritation and anger out of my voice.

"No, of course not. You're a grown man and Durene's only a young woman who looks up to you as an adult. Why should you apologize to her for telling the truth? Why should you feel guilty for hurting the feelings of a half-Troll? My mistake."

Prost's voice is rougher too, but he's still determined to be polite. I wonder why? It's not like I'd be able to beat him if he threw a punch. But maybe there's more in him than just bigotry and prejudice. Maybe he knows I'm right.

"You seem to feel I should be talking to Durene, Mister Laken?"

"I would never tell a grown man what to do. But they're so hard to find these days. No matter where *I* look, I can't see any."

Another shot, and I know it hits something. But Prost is a stubborn man, a farmer. He doesn't roll over, he digs in and keeps going. Reasonable tone, conciliatory words. I can tell he wants me to agree with him, to give a bit. Not happening.

"Durene is—useful. Helpful. She cares, I know that Mister Laken. And we're lucky to have her around some times. But she's still a half-Troll. And that means she's part monster. Not entirely Human. It makes us parents worry some nights. What can you say to that?"

Half-Troll. It's as if all Durene is, is just a word. How can they not see? She is more than that. She's a [Paladin]. What would he say if I mentioned that?

"She's a person, Mister Prost. A person. Where I come from—well, some people judge others based on what they look like it's true. But take it from a man who can't see, there's more than just sight that goes into people. If sight was all we judged by, why, wouldn't I be as much of a—a monster as Durene?"

Pause. Did anything I said go through? I hear Prost move about in the snow again, and then he speaks.

"It's hard to look at her and not be afraid, Mister Laken. Maybe if I had the courage to close my eyes I'd think differently when I spoke to her. But it's hard to get past."

"Hard, but necessary."

“There’s some truth to what you say, sir. I know Durene and she’d never hurt a fly. Maybe—”

Maybe. Just maybe you’ve been wrong. I wait for more, but that’s it.

“Well, I’ll give it some thought and let the others know what you’ve said. That’s all I can say, sir.”

“I’d appreciate that. And I will say that if one more person hints at Durene being not good enough or I hear that she’s a freak, I’ll start throwing things. And believe me, I have pretty good aim even if I can’t see.”

I could probably nail him with a snowball, at least around Durene’s cottage. But I won’t. He came here to talk to me about Durene, and I said my bit and he said his. If he changes, all for the better.

But Prost isn’t quite done. He stands there for a while longer, and I have the distinct feeling he’s looking me up and down. When he speaks next, he has that same odd note of respect in his voice. Why?

“You seem...taller, Mister Laken. Better than before, if you don’t mind me saying so.”

“Not at all. I’m glad I seem so healthy to you.”

Taller? What does he mean? But it’s clear Prost means more than just height. He’s about to leave when I hear Frostwing kicking up a fuss inside the cottage. Maybe she’s finally caught Prost’s scent, or she’s hungry again.

“What’s that sound?”

I shrug as Prost begins to sound nervous again.

“Oh, that? That’s a baby eagle I’m raising.”

“A baby—”

He chokes on the words.

“You’re just full of surprises, aren’t you Mister Laken? Where’d you find a baby eagle?”

“In the snow, just like everyone else.”

“And you’re going to raise it?”

“If I can keep trapping animals. Eagles only eat meat, which is sort of tough for me and Durene.”

I have a sudden thought.

“Say, Mister Prost, would you consider selling me some food? I’d be willing to pay you a good price for anything you can spare out of your larder.”

Prost sounds vaguely surprised at my offer. I guess he really only came up here to chat.

“Food, sir? I don’t know. It’s awfully dear at this time of year, and the harvest was good, but not so much that I’d want to let anything go for cheap.”

“How would a gold coin sound?”

An intake of breath. I wait patiently, face straight. Yes, I have quite a lot of money, don’t I? I’d nearly forgotten with Frostwing, but hey, if you’ve got it, why not spend it? And it’s not like I can eat gold.

Prost murmurs to himself in surprise. He seems to take for granted the fact that I have a gold coin—from what Durene says every family might have one gold coin’s worth in savings, but probably not more than that unless they work a more profitable job. It’s more hand-to-mouth around here.

“A gold coin? I’m not sure we can spare...”

“What about the other villagers? I don’t need much, but I’d like more eggs than Durene’s chickens provide, and I’d love to have enough meat to go round.”

“The villagers might ah, go for that. But a gold coin—at this time of year—well, I’d have to think about it.”

I nod seriously, as if I’m considering Prost’s words carefully. Then I rub my hand over my mouth as if in serious thought.

“How does this sound, then? One gold coin—for whatever dried meat, eggs, and so on you feel you can trade. If the rest of the village will add a bit from their stock, I’ll make it two gold coins. You can take the money, Mister Prost, and change it however you feel is right. And then you can bring me whatever my money’s worth.”

Credit to him, the other man’s voice sounds only slightly strangled as he replies.

“That’s—very generous of you, sir.”

I shrug, slightly.

“I have a bit of money saved up, and mouths to feed. And I’d like to repay Durene back for all the help she’s been to me. You understand that, don’t you?”

“I do indeed, sir. Well then, if you’re sure I’d happily accept.”

I hold out a hand, and Prost takes it and gives me a firm shake. His hand is callused and cold. Somehow rougher than Durene’s, even though she has

harder skin.

“Give me one second to get the coin.”

I love my Skill. Instead of having to search around desperately for the bag of coins and money, I find it in an instant. Durene hid it behind a sack, as if there were thieves lurking around the cottage. Then again, I suppose it would have been bad if Prost had entered the cottage and seen the bag lying around.

I take two gold coins out and come back to Prost in less than ten seconds.

“You’re awfully fast for a blind man, if you don’t mind my saying so, Mister Laken.”

“Blind doesn’t mean slow, Mister Prost.”

“Of course not.”

I give him the heavy coins and he promises to bring some food the next day. I have the distinct feeling he’s going to take as much of a cut as he can before paying the other villagers, but that’s pretty much why I made the offer in the first place. And if it means food—all the better.

Trade negotiations for the Empire of Laken or perhaps the Blind Empire have been concluded. All that’s left is to wait for Durene and give her the good news. She’s astounded of course, and a bit worried.

“Isn’t spending that much money—”

“Please, Durene. I found this bag by accident and there’s a hundred times what I just spent in here, easily. If it means we can feed this greedy sack of feathers, I’m all for it.”

I poke at Frostwing again, noting that she still does not, in fact, have feathers. Durene makes a noise which could be in agreement.

“How do you think I did in bargaining with Prost, though? Did I pay him too much?”

Durene thinks about this for a second.

“A gold coin? That’s...fair? A big, big basket full of meat and food would probably be a gold coin. Two is expensive, but it *is* winter.”

“And it’s enough to provide for another mouth and us comfortably throughout the winter. The villagers are happy, and so are we.”

Durene nods, or at least, I feel her do something as I sit next to her, sharing the blanket.

“It’s just—that’s a lot of money, Laken. I’ve never even seen more than three gold coins at once, and that’s how much the [Merchant] that visited

had.”

Three gold coins? That makes me smile, but sadly. I have a bag full of wealth beyond Durene’s imagination. And I? I have no sense of what it means to her. In a very real way, I don’t deserve it. But I will try to treat it seriously. After all, if I wasted the gift I was given, that would be even worse than not getting it at all.

“I think two gold coins is fine, Durene. We could use the food, and this way we’ll be able to eat more than just pottage every night. Moreover, it pays to be a bit generous, but not too much. Especially if they start asking how much money I have.”

Not that I think they’d risk Durene’s wrath. But the image of the angry mob haunts the back of my mind, and I think, Durene’s. Conversation sort of trails off after that, but I can’t help but feel it was a decent day’s work. Maybe Prost won’t change, but at the very least, I can pay him to feed us. That’s got to be worth something.

[Emperor Level 6!]

[Skill – Intimidating Glare obtained!]

“You have *got* to be kidding me.”

“Hmm...? Laken?”

“Nothing. Go back to sleep, Durene. And you too, Frostwing.”

Day 38

He did apologize to Durene, I think. I didn’t hear it myself, and reading between the lines of what Durene said, it was a briefer apology than I would have liked.

But it was something.

And we got the food! I think the basket containing the dried ham, eggs, cheeses, and other delicious goods was enough for Durene. I could practically hear her stomach growling as I took it from Prost. And by all accounts, the villagers were happy to give up some food for good coin. So we also earned a bit of goodwill. Score one for generosity.

Frostwing certainly appreciated the meat. She eats more day by day, and she’s bigger than she was before—substantially. I can feel her getting

restless and moving about more, and I wonder how big she'll get before she's able to fly.

Moreover, why was her nest so low to the ground, and in a tree no less? I thought eagles made their roosts high up. There's something about her—not to mention the fact that even after we've washed her, Durene says Frostwing's fuzz is *definitely* green.

I don't know. I'll have to wait and see. I've managed to train Frostwing a bit—she now knows not to poop in the nest and instead do it in another bowl nearby. Plus, she's stopped waking me up in my sleep! By this point, I'm a Level 4 [Beast Tamer], the product of much work and pecked fingers. No new Skills, but I consider my new friend a gift enough.

Durene's out helping clear snow in the village, and I'm sitting outside, Frostwing huddled in a scarf on my lap. I'm not sure if that's smart, but my bond with her will tell me when she's too cold, and I don't want her to just breathe stale air.

The air is crisp, but I'm warm and my stomach is full. It's a nice day. And then I feel it. Something enters the area around the cottage, swooping in from high above. Not something—*somethings*. I pause, warily, and Frostwing screeches in alarm. Then I hear the voice.

“Look! Look, sisters! I've found him! The one who rules over this small place!”

What the—? Did I just hear a voice? I turn my head as I hear laughter and feel something flying around me! A bug? A...bird? No. It has a voice! But there's no person standing around the cottage. I would feel it. Yet there is *something* in the air.

“Who's there?”

Laughter. A voice that sounds like falling snow and pure ice rings out, up and to the left, as if the speaker is flying. She calls to me.

“Can you not hear us, oh Emperor? We are here, Frost Faeries of the Winter Court to meet you! Are you not honored?”

“Frost Faeries?”

What's going on? Are there really *faeries* flying around my head? My first instinct is to disbelieve, but my sensible brain overrides that.

Okay, faeries. Durene tells me there's magic, so why not faeries? Wait, didn't she mention that name to me—

"You're Winter Sprites?"

More laughter from above me. Frostwing is squirming in my lap, making sounds of distress. I think she's afraid of these Frost Faeries, and that makes *me* wary. Already I can remember legends of the *sidhe*, and how they can be very, very dangerous. I try to remember what to do.

Be polite, be courteous. Offer them hospitality? Don't tell them my name or make promises.

I decide to roll with it. It's probably the best thing to do, but I throw in some healthy skepticism just to be on the safe side.

"Greetings, faeries. If that's who you really are."

Above me, I hear a mix of voices speak at once, a few outraged, some intrigued and playful. My god, it does sound like they're flying around me!

"You question us?"

"He does! Look! He cannot see us, only hear us!"

"He sees naught!"

"Aye, but he rules over this place nonetheless. Emperor of the Unseen!"

It's both terrifying and amazing. But when they mention that title I freeze in my seat.

"How do you know I called myself that?"

It was just a joke, said to Durene in the privacy of my cottage weeks ago. The faeries laugh and I feel something colder than freezing in front of my face. Is it right in front of me? I make no move.

"We heard your words. How could we not? Ye claimed this land to the world and all living in it!"

Heard my words? How?

"Well...I suppose I'm flattered that you're taking such notice of me. But what do faeries have to do with me?"

A tinkling laugh, like icicles breaking.

"We have come here to bear witness to you, of course!"

“Bear witness? Why?”

“Art thou not an [Emperor]?”

The faerie makes it sound as if it’s the most obvious thing in the world. And I start to get it. Faeries, kings—they’re tied together, like how the faeries blessed Briar Rose in the original tale. And they’ve come to visit me?

“I’m honored, of course. But have you come to simply see and acknowledge me, or do you have some other reason? And shouldn’t you be bowing? I *am* an [Emperor].”

I’m playing a dangerous and probably stupid game. But the faerie in front of me laughs again, apparently taken with my boldness.

“Hah! We bow to no mortal sovereign. You may claim the land, but we are far more than mere dirt and plant. Your authority has no sway over we.”

“And yet you acknowledge it exists.”

“Of course! What churls do you think we are?”

“We came to bear witness!”

“To see an Emperor of this small place!”

“And because we had nothing better to do!”

Well then, it sounds to me like these faeries came here because they were bored. Which means they’re capricious. Better to get on their good side. But how? I don’t know if offering them food is any good—I’d have to make some, and all of Durene’s cooking utensils are made of iron.

“Well then, in the name of the Unseen Empire, I bid you welcome. You are all honored guests, although I regret that my master chef and seneschal is out chopping wood. Please, make yourselves at home.”

The faeries seem delighted at this.

“Oho!”

“He is polite, this one! He knows how to treat us: with respect!”

“Not like those other fools!”

I wonder who they're talking about. I sense the faeries flying lower, and inquire politely.

"Do you have any business here besides meeting me? I wouldn't want to keep you from your duties."

A chorus of denials greets me.

"Nae, we have time."

"Until the spring comes, we are free!"

"Free to do as we please, and not follow one stupid mortal!"

"Aye! So we came here to meet you! 'Twas worth it to be greeted with respect."

Another voice chimes in, high and excited.

"Plus, we wanted to see ye before it was too late."

"Shh! Don't tell him that!"

"Wait, *what?*"

"Idiot!"

I hear a light smack and I have to guess one of the faeries hit the other. I hold Frostwing in my hands, although she's barely moving, heart suddenly beating out of my chest. Faeries. Beings that can see and predict fate.

"There's something bad about to happen? Please, tell me."

"Well—"

"Shh! Be *quiet!*"

"No. Forget what you heard, mortal!"

The faeries flutter around me. They start arguing, and I hear a few of them saying they should tell me. But most of them are in favor of not. A few fly up, and I raise my voice desperately.

"Wait, hold on! I entreat you, please, stay and let us talk."

A pause, and then I sense them flying close to me.

“Very well. For your words of hospitality, we will listen. Speak, oh Emperor, Protector of Durene’s Cottage.”

No time to laugh, and no time to question. I clear my throat.

“It seems to me that you...wise and noble faeries are aware of some impending danger to me and my empire that I am not aware of.”

“Perhaps.”

“Indeed, and I would *never* ask you to reveal a secret. But perhaps I could persuade you to help me avert the tragedy that is yet to come? Or at the very least, reveal the danger to me.”

The faeries murmur at this. I hold my breath—I’m trying to sound formal, but I have no idea how to actually talk to the fae. A bargain with them sounds like a bad idea, but this disaster—

“Intriguing. What do you propose, mortal?”

Yatzhee! I keep my face composed as I nod in what I hope is a dignified manner.

“Well, I cannot offer you land or a marriage to my house—”

“—Hah!”

“Shh!”

“—But what would you say to mortal riches? I have gold and jewels to compliment your radiance. Would you accept that?”

The faeries confer, whispering loudly.

“Mm...*maybe*.”

“Hah! He seeks to flatter us. He calls us ‘radiant’, he who cannot see!”

“Ah, but we *are* radiant, are we not sisters? Any mortal can tell that, even without sight.”

“True! But gold is so *heavy*. And it *is* a secret.”

In the end, they fly back down to me, probably shaking their tiny heads. I can only imagine.

“No, oh Emperor. It is not enough. Mortal wealth has little luster for us. Have you nothing else to offer?”

Nothing. Damn it, nothing. Only a bit of food, and I can’t feed all of them! If only I had an actual empire. But my [Emperor] title is just for show. I can only—

Wait. Emperor. Empire. What about—

I clear my throat.

“What if I gave you a noble title?”

“What?”

“Really?”

“Are you serious, mortal?”

Am I? Yes.

“Only naturally. I would offer entrance into my noble court to any friend of my kingdom. You, for instance—”

I point in the direction of the voice of the faerie that just spoke.

“For your aid, would you accept a title? That of, say, Comtesse?”

“Ooh! I like that!”

“What about us?”

“I want to be a Comtesse!”

“Nay, I!”

“We cannot all be Comtesses! What of the rest of us, mortal?”

Jeez, do I have to bribe all of them? I think quickly.

“I could make you...*noblesse uterine* if you wanted.”

Not exactly a flattering name. The tiny voices confer, and then dissent.

“Nay! Another title!”

“Marchioness, then? Or—how about *Herzogin*?”

“Ooh! I like that!”

“I want to be that!”

“No, me!”

They’re like children, squabbling over titles I just made up. And yet—maybe there’s more to it than that. It might sound funny, but I am an Emperor, and I do have the power to make the nobility.

...Still, I can’t help but feel glad that no one’s watching me as I come outside and address one of the faeries who kneels in the air in front of me.

“Very well. I dub thee Comtesse of the Soup Spoon.”

So saying, I hand her a wooden spoon. The other faeries *ooh* and applaud, and the faerie seizes the spoon from my hand and crows in triumph. That position was heavily sought after, but the other titles are equally as important. I turn to the next faerie.

“If you would be a *Reichsgräfin* in my empire—”

“Aye, I would!”

“Then I grant you that position for as long as my empire exists. To the end of time, an Emperor’s word on it.”

“Hah! I will hold you to your word, mortal!”

That’s what worries me. But I have no time to reflect on my actions. I go down the line of faeries. A Comtesse, several Ladies, a Duchess and a Viscount—I dub a score of them *Blumenritter*, and make one a Baron. I asked her if she wanted to be a Baroness, but she preferred Baron.

And then it’s over. I breathe out and feel the assembled peerage of my empire flying before me. I bow to them regally, and hear them laugh in delight. The sound warms my heart even in this chill, but I am still afraid.

“So now will you tell me what fate waits for my empire?”

The faeries pause.

“We cannot say.”

Really? After all this? I only cross my arms and frown. The faeries hurry on.

“We cannot! It is a secret and not our place to tell. But since ye have given us an Emperor’s gift, we shall return your kindness. I swear to you, oh mortal ruler, this fate shall not befall your land or your people.”

Is that a good thing or a bad thing? No—it’s good. And I know better than to question it. Instead, I nod my head regally.

“My thanks to you. You and your kind are welcome in my land. Know this.”

“Aye, and we shall treasure your gifts to us, mortal!”

“You shall be safe, we promise!”

“You aren’t bad—for an Emperor!”

The faeries cry out as they laugh and fly away from me. I listen to them go, worried and relieved and happy in turns. Faeries. My god.

Durene finds me sitting in the snow, about an hour later. I hear her exclaim and then come running over.

“*Laken!* What’s wrong? Why are you out here? You’re so *cold!*”

I just laugh at her, which makes her even more confused and upset. I let her carry me inside and fuss over me. I barely know where to begin. How can I even explain what happened? I do my best, but she can hardly believe me herself. But there is one thing I now know, with dreadful certainty.

“Something bad is about to happen, Durene.”

It might avoid us, according to the faeries. But I cannot help but wonder and worry. It may be mortal folly, but I am mortal. And I worry. But that is only half of me. The other half wonders and dreams of magic.

I saw faeries.

[Emperor Level 7!]

Day 41

Three days later it happened. I was just waking up, in that blissful moment between waking and sleeping. I was about to feed Frostwing some cold meat when I heard a *roar* like thunder. But unlike thunder, the sound did not diminish. Rather, it grew louder.

“*Durene!*”

Maybe I was expecting it. But the reality of the ground *shaking* around me and Durene's pottery clattering and breaking on the shelves is far more horrific than anything I could have dreamed. I hear Frostwing screeching, and Durene shouting for me.

We meet in the center of the cottage as the rumbling oblivion of noise crescendos around us. It feels like the world is ending, and all I can do is hold Durene to me. I feel her squeezing me hard, and close my eyes.

And then, as quick as the terror has begun, it's over. I open my eyes slowly, for the first time in ages. Of course I see nothing, but I do it all the same. It feels like I *should* see something, for the world has changed.

I know it, even if the cottage and the area around it that I can sense is the same. Durene is quivering in my arms. As she holds me and I hold her, I can hear Frostwing *shrieking* in alarm. At last I manage to let go of Durene and stagger up to her.

"Frostwing. Are you...?"

She's alright. Just scared out of her wits. I check her with my hands just to be sure. They're shaking. Then I hear Durene gasp.

"Durene. What is it?"

"The—the—"

She can't even speak. I rush to her side, and feel her at the open door. But I can't sense anything.

"Durene?"

"The *snow*..."

Her eyes see it. But it takes me a long time, an eternity, to coax her mouth into making sense for me. And then she speaks and I realize what's happened.

The snow. The snow came down off of a distant mountain. The snow, triggered by snowfall or a sound or the faeries, turned into an avalanche that poured down, smashing everything in its way. It travelled miles, a vast distance, before expending the last of its energy here.

Even the last of its force is enough to destroy everything in its path. Trees were uprooted, a good swathe of the forest buried. But by some miracle—some magical help—the force of the avalanche split around the hut. Ours is the only unburied point as far as Durene can see.

"It's a miracle."

Durene hugs me again, shaking. I hug her back, even though I know that's not entirely true. Not a miracle. A gift. Payment in kind.

I don't know if I should thank the faeries or blame them. I settle for thanking them, and feel relief coursing through my veins. It's over. We're safe. If the faeries hadn't diverted the avalanche, the cottage would have been buried or smashed to bits. I'm just glad we weren't outside of the cottage or—

My heart stops in my chest. I realize with horror what must have happened. My sightless gaze turns to the road connecting Durene's cottage with the rest of the world, now covered in snow.

"Oh no. The village."

Durene gasps in horror. She lets go of me.

"It would've been right in the way of the avalanche! Laken, what should we do? We have to—do you think it missed them?"

No, no I don't. I can just imagine what happened. The avalanche hit the village. I might've—the buildings are sturdy and this was the tail end of it. But what good is that against thousands of tons of snow?

Durene is panicking, and I'm rooted to one spot. We have to help. But how? It's just me and Durene. Should I grab a shovel? No—food? What's the best option? Where will the villagers go? Is it still dangerous there?

I don't know what the right choice is here. I don't know how to save the lives that might be at risk—or already gone.

Think, Laken. What can I *do*? What can we do?

What would an [Emperor] do?

3.12 E

What do I do?

I'm no hero. I'm not even qualified to be a police officer, doctor, an emergency worker, or any job that requires sight.

And I've never been trained. I have no idea what to do.

So panic grips me as I stumble across the snowy ground, knees still shaking from the avalanche. Part of me doesn't even really *believe* what's happened. After all, the small area of land I can sense hasn't changed much. But Durene tells me that everything around her cottage is just—gone.

'I'll have to see it to believe it.' Ironical, but in my case I have to *feel* it, or at least hear it to believe. I walk to the edge of the place where the earth just fades away in my mind, and feel forwards.

Nothing. Well, it's not as if there would be a wall of ice in front of me. But suddenly I notice the frozen pathway is gone. Instead, there's only crunching snow underfoot. And as I walk forwards cautiously, feeling my way ahead, I start to stumble as I run into huge chunks of solid snow, torn up. And—dirt? I hit something hard and feel at it.

A tree trunk. Sideways. It's lying on the ground.

"Oh no."

It's true. I trace my way to the base of the trunk—actually, it's the top of the tree. I feel branches, and leaves. The avalanche pulled this tree up and tossed it like a twig. And if it could do this to a tree, what chance does a house stand?

The village. My mind goes back to it. What do I do? What *can* I do? I have to help; that's the right choice. But what's the best way? I don't—

"*Laken!*"

A voice shouts my name and I hear thumping footsteps. Durene rushes after me, fright clear in her voice.

"It's not safe!"

Rough hands drag me back. Durene is terrified, but she cares more about my safety in this moment than anything else. I let her pull me back into the radius of the cottage. There at least I can tell what's around me. But instead of being reassured by my mastery of this small domain, I now feel like I'm holding a candle in a—a dark world. I don't understand darkness

that well, but I fear the place where my [Emperor]’s senses fade away and I have to rely solely on remaining senses.

The village. My heart is still pounding out of my chest. The world is too silent. I can hear thunder in my veins, but there is only silence in the air. Compared to the fury of a few seconds ago, this—

I hear shrieking. My head turns, but it’s only Frostwing. She’s scared out of her mind, and I can’t blame her. But her anxiety doesn’t matter—the village—

I can’t think. I’m hyperventilating, gasping for air. Durene trembles as she stops.

“Laken. What do we...? It’s all gone.”

We’re both in shock. I know that. But my mind keeps snapping back to the village. Riverfarm. They were hit. I have to do something.

And like that, the paralysis gripping me ends. It’s not that I’m not still petrified. But I start moving even so. I have to act. It’s either act or keep still, and there *is no time*.

“Durene, we have to go to the village. The faeries didn’t protect Riverfarm. Who knows what’s happened to them?”

“What? Laken—”

Durene pauses. It’s not even complete thoughts she’s having. She’s not thinking, just reacting. But finally—and it feels like forever although it’s only been a minute or less—my brain begins working again.

Village. Help them. We have to go and check. Can’t stay here.

I feel cold. As if my skin and everything beneath it has frozen over. A chill made of fear is making me shake, but that same terror is electric. I don’t stop and think; I only know that I have to *move*.

“We have to go! *Durene!*”

I snap at her. Durene jerks, and then she hesitates.

“It’s too dangerous for you! I’ll go. I’ll help. You stay here and—”

“No.”

“Laken—”

“You are a [Paladin].”

I feel like an idiot saying it, but I grab Durene’s protective hand and try to turn my head towards her face. My gentle giant is shivering with fear, but her being here reassures me enough to keep my voice steady.

“Durene. You are a Paladin. A protector of the weak and innocent. And you are also *my* guardian, my champion. You have to go. And I have to go.

We have to help everyone we can.”

She hesitates, and then I feel a bit of strength return to her hand. She breathes in.

“Okay. Let’s go. I’ll clear a way. The road is—is gone. Follow me.”

She turns, and I hesitate. The village. What will we do there?

Think—it was an avalanche. Buried people, disaster area. Red Cross. Doctors Without Borders. What do they...?

“No—wait.”

Durene halts in bewilderment. I turn and point towards the cottage.

“A basket. We need all the food we can put in there, towels—clean fabric—um—”

I can’t think of anything else. Bandages, food, what else? The avalanche
—

“A shovel.”

I run back towards the cottage, and Durene rushes into her tool shed for a shovel. I push open the door and hear Frostwing screaming at me. She’s tumbled out of her nest, but fortunately she’s okay. I scoop her up and put her and the nest on the floor. I talk to her as I scramble around the cottage, using the clear image of the cottage in my head to pick up everything we might need.

“It’s okay. It’s okay—shush! We’ll be back, okay?”

To my surprise, the eaglet shuts up. I don’t have time to dwell on that though—six more seconds and I’m kicking the door open. Durene grabs the food and cloth spilling out of my arms and stuffs it into a huge basket she uses to collect produce.

“Okay. Let’s go!”

I lead us both away from the cottage. It’s so easy to move around Durene’s cottage. I’ve seldom ever run—being blind means I’m used to running into things, and I know that I can seriously injure myself running into something sharp at high speed. But in this place I’m sure-footed, and I force my unaccustomed legs to move faster. Durene is right behind me, carrying the basket.

Two steps outside of the circle and I falter. The world disappears around me, my sense of it returning to nothing. It wouldn’t have bothered me, before. But it’s like going deaf or losing my sense of smell. Or going blind, I suppose. The new sense I had is gone, and I suddenly realize how inconvenient it is not to have it.

I stumble, and a hand catches me.

“This way. Follow me.”

I take hold of the bottom of Durene’s shirt and begin to follow her. That’s easy—I’ve done that countless times before. But this time, the landscape is totally different.

“So much snow...”

I can feel Durene’s shirt straining as she grunts and pushes ahead. The snow around my ankles rises and shifts, and as I follow in her steps I realize that the snow rapidly becomes waist-deep in places.

No time to stop and think. I try to follow directly in Durene’s footsteps. But even then, the snow is already filling in her steps, and I can’t tell what’s in front of me.

The snow is so *deep*! Durene wades through it, but I can’t. The second time I trip, something grabs my legs and back, pulling me off my feet. I jerk in surprise, but Durene lifts me into her arms, cradling me with ease.

“I’ll—carry you, Laken. It’s faster that way.”

My mouth opens to object. I’m not a child. But then I close my mouth instead. She’s right. Even if I had sight, this is probably faster.

“I’ll hold the basket. Give it to me.”

I hold the basket on my stomach as Durene carries me in her arms. It is *not* comfortable, especially since Durene’s running means I bounce around like a rag doll. But she moves far faster than I can, so I hang on to her with all my strength as I feel cold air blowing past my face.

Powdery flecks of ice keep hitting me. Durene is churning through the snow as if it’s not there. I can hear her breathing hard, but she doesn’t stop running.

Riverfarm is about ten minutes away from Durene’s cottage at walking speed. We get there in four minutes. My first instinct when Durene puts me down is to find the wounded. But my weak imagination isn’t enough to predict the reality of what awaits us.

For a few seconds after Durene puts me on the uneven earth, she can’t even speak. When she eventually finds her tongue, it’s still almost too much for her. She describes the scene for me, breathless. Horrified.

Riverfarm is *gone*. The avalanche poured through the tiny community in one horrific rush. The pounding snow covered entire houses and knocked the walls in on others. There’s so much packed snow that we’re standing several feet *above* where the ground is supposed to be.

“I can see the roof of Mister Prost’s house from here. It—oh, Laken! It’s all gone!”

“What about the people, Durene? Are they alive?”

I grab Durene’s arm, trying to keep her focused. My voice is urgent, and she starts as if coming out of a trance.

“A few. I can see some, but—”

Some of them are just standing around, motionless. Others wander aimlessly, and I can hear them calling. A few are trying to dig at the ground, but the snow isn’t loose. It’s been packed, and everything is buried. How would they even know where their families and friends are?

And no one’s really that coherent in the first place. Durene is experiencing it and so am I, to a lesser extent.

Shock. But I know—I have to fight through it. I can’t see, but I wasn’t caught up in that maelstrom of death. My head is the clearest right now.

“We have to start digging people out. Durene, where’s the nearest house?”

Again, Durene starts as if I’m waking her from a dream.

“Nearest? Over there—Mister Ballus and Miss Ven’s—”

“Let’s go to it.”

I push at her, and Durene moves forwards. I follow her until she stops.

“What does it look like? Do you see any of the family around here?”

“No—I—I don’t know. They could be over there. That looks like—it’s all buried, Laken. All of it.”

“How much is buried? The front? The back? Could we dig the door out—maybe they’re still inside?”

“I don’t know. It’s *buried*.”

I clench my teeth in frustration. I can’t see, and Durene isn’t being helpful. I want to shout at her, but in the next instant I feel her moving.

“I’ll dig! Stand back, Laken!”

I take the basket and move back. At once I feel snow flying through the air and hear Durene grunting. Suddenly she’s all motion, and I hear her shouting, the first loud sound in the shocked silence of the village.

“Mister Ballus! Miss Ven! Cinney! Rober! Are you there!?”

The noise does something to the villagers not buried by the snow. After a few seconds I hear movement, and then someone runs over.

“*Durene!*? And – Mister Laken? You two are alive?”

“We are.”

I don't recognize the name, but I feel someone rush over to me. A hand seizes mine, rough and callused.

"It's me, Prost."

"Mister Prost? Are you okay? Where's your family?"

"I don't see them. *I don't—*"

Prost is trembling even worse than Durene was. He can barely hold on to me, but that he does, clutching at me like he's holding on for dear life. I try to calm him down.

"Mister Prost. Listen to me. We have to start digging people out. Durene's got a shovel. Can you help her? Find other people...?"

We need to get a group of people assembled. Even with Durene's strength, every house in the village is drowned in snow. Prost nods, and then realizes I can't see the motion even though I feel him doing it.

"I can do that. But—Durene! My house is over there!"

"Mister Prost?"

I feel the man let go, and then hear Durene's voice. The sound of the shovel scraping the snow stops.

"My family—they were all inside when the avalanche hit! Help me dig them out!"

"But Mister Ballus and his family are—"

Oh no. I hear the two's voices raised, and then it sounds like Prost tries to grab the shovel out of Durene's hand. When that doesn't work, he tries to drag her with him with the same amount of success.

"Please, you have to help. They're trapped! I need—"

"*Durene!*"

This voice isn't from a man. It's female and cracks in desperation. I hear more running and then another villager is fighting with Prost for Durene's attention.

"*Durene!*"

"Help me! My husband—"

"Help *us!*"

I can see nothing, but I don't have to see to know that Prost shoves the other woman away. I hear her cry out, and then Durene's voice.

"Stop fighting! Please! I'll try to get everyone out. But if you could help me—"

"My family! Save them first!"

No, no, *no*! But I know even as the voices raise what's going to happen. The villagers were still shocked when Durene and I arrived. But now that we've started moving, the confusion gripping the villagers has faded a bit.

But that only means they're now desperate, and Durene is the only person that can help them. More people rush to her, an uninjured beacon of hope. But instead of working together, they begin fighting over her!

"Everyone! Please listen! We need to work together!"

I call out, shouting at them, but I can't see a thing, and Durene is now trapped by the desperate men and women. They're arguing, not listening to anything. And instantly, a scuffle begins. I even hear what sounds like a blow. Are they *hitting* each other? But it's every villager for themselves.

"*Listen to me!*"

I shout desperately and even try to run towards the fight, but all that gets me is a hard shove as someone knocks me down. I fall onto the ice and hear a scream.

"Laken!"

Someone else shrieks, and then I hear the voice moving away. Durene runs towards me. She—*threw* a villager out of the way. They scatter as she anxiously helps me up.

"Are you okay?"

"I am—but this is insanity, Durene!"

I'm already on my feet. But the sounds of chaos haven't faded. If anything, they've gotten worse. Now the people are fighting over Durene's shovel. She's helpless as she looks at the scene and I try to make sense of it all.

"No one's listening! What should I do, Laken?"

I don't know. This is a nightmare—two nightmares at the same time! We need order, but no one's listening. And I have no idea where the buried villagers are, or even how many are still alive. I yell at Durene.

"Just—just start digging! Try to get this house out first. We have to—"

What can I do? Nothing. I could dig, but I have no idea where everything is. And Durene's the only person with any kind of tool! She moves into action, running back towards the building and I cup my hands to my mouth and shout.

But it does no good. No one will listen to me. Eventually, the fighting villagers stop and return to trying to dig their loved ones out. One helps Durene, and others try to get their friends to work together, but there's no

cohesion. And again, there's only one shovel and the ice is like stone in places. And no one knows where any of the victims are!

We're running out of time. People are suffocating down there. I try to think. What can I do? What can any of us do?

What if—I could see? I can't, but what about my Skill? Yes, that's right! I saw Durene's cottage, and even the buried plants in the garden. What if—

I take a few deep breaths. No one is looking at me and Durene is still shouting as she digs. I don't know what to do exactly, so I point to what the center of the village is. I try to put conviction into my words as I speak.

"I claim this village."

Nothing happens. Of course not. Would it really be that simple? But then what do I do?

"I claim this village—in the name of [Emperor] Laken!"

"...This village is a Protectorate of the Unseen Empire!"

Nothing. I feel like the biggest fool in the world, and all around me people are screaming, calling for help. *Dying*.

I have to do something. And this is it. Why can't I claim this village? I could do it with Durene's cottage. Think. Why?

Because she *let* me. Because she gave me the authority to do it. Instantly, I realize what I have to do.

"Durene? *Durene*?"

She's by my side in an instant.

"What is it, Laken?"

"Where's the village head?"

I know this village has its own mayor, or leader or something. It's not a very important position—the villagers choose someone every year, but only to negotiate with other villagers, towns, and traders. But it is a leader.

"What? Mister Till? I don't know. I don't see him..."

"I need to find him. Or his family. Do you see anyone who knows where he might be?"

"N—I do! I see his wife!"

"Take me to her. Hurry!"

Durene abandons her efforts and leads me across the uneven ground. I keep stumbling, and at one point I hear a shout and feel the packed snow *shifting* underneath me.

"God."

Is this what it's like after an earthquake? I've heard stories of natural disasters, but this—

I don't know what it looks like. But to my mind, the world is in chaos. Nothing is the same as when I came here a few days ago. It's like I've walked into another world again. A horrible world of death and fear.

"Miss Feya! Miss Feya!"

Someone's in front of me. I hear sobbing, and then someone's in front of me.

"Durene? Oh Durene—help me! My poor boy is down there somewhere!"

"I—I'll try to find him!"

I hear the sounds of Durene digging with her hands. I reach out, and there's a woman in front of me. My hand recoils as I touch her frozen skin and find sticky blood.

"Miss...Feya?"

"Who is—oh! You're..."

"I'm Laken."

There's no time for niceties. I guide the trembling woman a bit away from Durene and then get straight to the point.

"Miss Feya, do you know where your husband is? He's the village head, isn't he?"

"My husband...?"

She's in shock too. I want to shake her, but I just wait for her, prodding gently.

"I need to find him. Do you know where he is?"

Even if he can't transfer ownership of the village to me, he might be able to rally the disorganized villagers. But I can already sense something's wrong.

"He—he—"

Choked words. I reach out and feel her shaking. Miss Feya sobs and I know what's happened.

"I'm so sorry."

But there's no time even for that. I hesitate. Would she be next in charge? I have to try.

"Feya. Miss Feya. I need you to give Riverfarm to me."

An intake of breath.

"Give? What are you talking about? There's nothing *left*!"

“I can’t explain everything, but—I have a Skill. It can help find people, even under the snow, I think. But I need to own this village to use it.”

“A Skill?”

I sound like a complete and absolute loon in my ears. But to Miss Feya, saying that might have been the best thing I could do. She understands Skills, even if she doesn’t know what I’m talking about. But she’s still hesitating, uncertain.

“You need the village?”

“Yes.”

“Can you really save them?”

There’s hope in her voice as well as doubt. But the world’s collapsed around her, and this poor woman is reaching out for any shred of hope. I don’t want to lie to her, so I tell her the truth.

“I can try.”

One second goes by as she thinks. Two. But she has nothing to lose, and everything to gain.

“It’s yours. If you can do something, please, do it!”

I nod and step back from her. I still feel self-conscious, but this time I don’t waver. I raise my head and speak with all the confidence I can muster.

“I claim this village. I claim Riverfarm.”

Nothing. Again. I curse and hear Feya moan. What’s wrong?

Last time—it took a while before I realized that I could sense Durene’s cottage. Maybe there’s a waiting time? If so, I’m screwed. But maybe it didn’t work because Miss Feya isn’t the next village head. She wasn’t elected, and—does the village head have the ability to speak for an entire village anyways?

Damn it, there’s just so much I don’t *know*! I feel helpless, and angry as well. I have to do something! But nothing I’ve tried has worked and I can hear Durene. She’s barely excavated more than a few feet of snow, and it’s been over ten minutes since we got here. If anyone’s still alive—

No time. No way. The burning helplessness in my chest intensifies. And I hear the same whispering in my heart that I think everyone’s heard before.

Just give up. You can’t do anything.

It’s the same voice that used to talk to me on the worst nights. It’s the voice that told me a blind kid couldn’t ever do anything. It tries to drag me down.

I am an [Emperor]. But I'm not one, really. I just went through the motions. I'm an actor and I put on a good play, but in the end the genuine article is different from me.

Emperor Norton never questioned himself. Charlemagne, Peter the Great, Leopold—did any of these people ever act like I did? How would I know?

What would an [Emperor] do?

The little voice in my head mocks me as I listen to people cry out. More than anything, I want to help them. But how? I don't own this village. There's a wall in my way, a wall I can't touch or feel or sense. I can't break it down. And there's a wall in the ground, a tomb of snow.

My doubts taunt me. But more than anything I want to act. The Emperor does not wait. He doesn't hesitate. He does what an Emperor does because he *is* an Emperor. If Norton ever asked questions, he would never have become an Emperor.

And I—

I can't let something silly like rules stop me. I don't own this village? That's not something a real [Emperor] would accept.

My heart is pounding. I don't ask questions. I stop hesitating.

People are dying. I want to help them. Have to. Durene is doing her best, but for all her strength, she's just one person. The villagers are disunited. There's no one to lead them. No one but me.

So I draw the biting air into my chest and *scream*.

"My name is Laken Godart! I claim this village!"

My voice cuts through the other noises, bringing quietus with it. I can tell everyone's stopped to stare at me in astonishment. But I don't falter. I don't wait, either. I keep shouting, so that everyone can hear me.

"Riverfarm is under my protection! All those who live within it are part of my empire!"

What's this? No one understands. Who's this blind young man, shouting nonsense? They're just words. Anyone can speak nonsense. Anyone can claim anything they want.

But who has the courage to shout it to the world? I do. So I shout and tell everyone that I *am* an Emperor, because it is true. I will make it true.

"I am Laken, Emperor of the Unseen! If anyone would challenge me, fight my champion, my [Paladin]. Durene!"

For a few seconds I think the villagers are too shocked to even respond. Then I hear a shout.

“Are you insane?”

Prost’s voice is angry. I can hear him moving towards me, but my attention isn’t on that. It’s on the snow under my feet. And the faint sense I have—

Below me is ice. Below that is timber. And then stone. A wall. And pressed up against that wall is a child. He barely moves, but he *does* move. He’s trapped against the wall and the snow is so constricting that he can only breathe and move a tiny bit. I see his chest rising and falling in my head.

“What nonsense are you shouting!?”

A hand grabs me. I hear an angry voice, and then more voices.

“You claim our village? By what right?”

“What are you doing?”

“We need help! Stop shouting and—*Durene!* Come here!”

The villagers have come to me. Of course they would. Here’s this crazy guy shouting at them as they’re in the middle of their grief and desperation. They want to unload their anger onto me. But I’m too busy to care.

“I am an [Emperor].”

They hear me, but who would believe that? They shout at me, and then I hear Durene’s voice.

“Let him go!”

A massive hand moves, and separates Prost from me with ease. He stumbles back, and I hear shouts.

“Durene! Come here!”

“*My children are down there!* Come with me!”

“You bastard—give me that shovel!”

Screaming. Fighting. Cries for help. I hear it all and see the boy breathing far below. Is this sight? It’s never been so clear to me. I breathe in and out and the world comes into focus.

This is mine. I claim it. It’s not sharp in my head; it’s not my village entirely. But I will have it.

The villagers are fighting. No one will get any work done. I’m angry at them. I know they’re afraid. So am I! But if they can’t work together everyone loses. Durene is shielding me with her body and shouting at them, but she’s no leader. Not yet.

But I am. I am an [Emperor]. I shout.

“Silence!”

And there is. Complete silence. My voice is thunder, and I feel that same sensation in my bones as I did once before, when I shouted at the group of children tormenting Durene, so long ago.

“I am an Emperor.”

My voice is the one sound in the empty world around me. I can feel people staring at me, but they are mute. I keep talking, my voice growing louder.

“Your families, your friends, are all trapped under the snow. I can find them. You will help me. Find something to dig with. We’ll start here. Give Durene her shovel back.”

No one moves. They’re in shock. I don’t have time for it. My hand raises. My voice grows deeper, and it echoes.

“You and you, find something to dig with. You! The shovel! The rest of you, start digging right *here*. **Move!**”

They move. They can’t help it. But they want to move as well; I’ve given them purpose. I’ve given them hope. I look down with my head and sense the small body beneath me. Growing colder. Growing weaker.

So many. So still. I sense tiny bodies and large ones, motionless beneath the snow. Some still move. Others lie at odd angles, in pieces.

There’s no time to grieve. I point and shout.

“Start digging there! And *there!*”

It’s like a game. An awful game where each second counts and the prize isn’t measured in points, but real lives. But there are ways to be more efficient.

“There are two shovels here. Dig them up!”

They’re nearest to the surface. If we have those, the villagers won’t have to use the branches and broken bits of wood. Durene is already clearing snow with her spade. I’ll have to stop her from hitting the boy when she gets close.

“Over there! She’s right beneath the snow! Dig with your hands and pull her out!”

I run, and people follow me. I shout, and they listen. There’s no little voice in my head. There’s only a screaming idiot, moving too fast to doubt himself. Every step I take in the snow is sure; my blood is electric. I dash over to the spot and people begin to dig.

“Follow me. Find something to dig with!”
Onwards. I let the villagers dig out their friends and run on.
I’m going to save everyone I can. This—
This is my village now. And I will protect it. I am an [Emperor].
I run and run, and forget that I’m blind. I forget everyone else. I reach down, and pull life out of the ground.

He only knew it hurt. He had tried screaming, but there was blackness all around him. Cold. It was so cold, and he knew he was buried. His head was full of pain and he knew he was bleeding. It was cold—

But also hot. The air in the small pocket where he was trapped was getting warmer, and every time he took a breath, his head spun.

He was dying.

He wanted to struggle, but he couldn’t even move. He cried and screamed, but no one had heard him. And now he was going to die.

That’s what he knew. He knew it even as he shouted for salvation. And then he heard the scraping.

Someone was digging! Towards him? He shouted desperately, barely daring to hope. But the sounds—they were coming from below him! They were going the wrong way! He screamed again, telling them to come back.

No! Had they missed him? The young man shouted desperately, and then realized the sound was getting louder, not softer! It was coming towards his head!

And then he realized something was off. Snow was breaking around his legs. He could move them! He wriggled with mad desperation, not caring if he hurt himself. He had to get out!

“Don’t worry. I’ve got you.”

A voice pulled him out of the madness. The young man froze, and then realized what was happening.

“You’re upside down. Don’t move and we’ll dig you out.”

The world turned over. Suddenly, the pounding in his head made sense. He waited, unable to bear the waiting but waiting nonetheless, and then felt a warm hand on his leg.

“You’re safe. Hold on just for a second longer.”

He didn't know the voice. He knew everyone in the village, but he didn't know the voice. But the hand was warm, and the voice was full of so much confidence—

He cried like a child as the warm hands dug the snow away and then came for him. He was still sobbing as more hands righted him and he was pulled out of the snow and back into the world of color and light.

For a little while he couldn't see. Tears made his vision blurry and he could only gulp in air, the sweetest, purest thing he'd ever felt in his life. He didn't want to grow up anymore. He didn't want to become a famous adventurer or leave this small village. He didn't want to marry his childhood crush.

He just wanted to be alive. And he was. The young man wept and clutched at the cold ground, and then remembered his name.

Gamel.

When he could finally think again, Gamel looked around and saw what had become of his home. Ice and snow had buried Riverfarm, the only place he had ever known. His house, his father's home that he had lived in and hated for being so small, was gone.

And so was the rest of the world. Gamel looked, but he couldn't see anything familiar. Where was the forest? Where was the river? Where were the road and the other houses?

He saw nothing familiar, save for a few rooftops and broken wood. But then he saw the people.

The villagers of Riverfarm numbered little over a hundred. He knew all of them by name, if not as friends. He recognized over thirty of them now, digging up the snow in teams. But one person stood out among the frantic workers, one person Gamel didn't recognize.

It was another young man, like Gamel. He had to be the blind man, the one who was staying at Durene's cottage. The one who liked the half-Troll.

But then the blind man turned and pointed. His eyes were closed, but he seemed to know where things were. He shouted, and Gamel realized that he was the owner of the voice and the warm hands.

And when he heard the voice, Gamel stood up. He ran over to help, even before he quite knew what he was doing. And when he did know, he only ran faster. His friends were buried. His family! His love.

The blind young man had found a woman trying to excavate her house. Her hands were raw and bleeding from digging. But she still turned the

snow crimson as she searched for any clue, any hint of her child.

“Miss.”

The young man pulled her away. She resisted, but two other villagers pulled her back. She was sobbing, crying out for her missing child. Gamel looked at the ground, but he could see nothing but packed snow. Where would you even begin searching for a missing kid? He could have been swept away, or buried in a pocket. You could dig for hours and not find him.

But the blind man only hesitated for one second. He seemed to search the ground and then pointed.

“There.”

Gamel stared. But men and women rushed forwards with hoes, shovels, even a board of wood, anything they could dig with. They began to send up flurries of snow where the blind man had pointed, digging with all their strength, totally confident in his prediction.

“Fifteen feet down. He isn’t moving.”

The blind man was supervising the work. He was also speaking to the mother. Gamel stared, and then saw two closed eyelids swing towards him. The not-gaze made him freeze. He couldn’t see him. But—

“You! Find something to dig with! Hurry!”

Gamel was running before he knew what had been said. He came back with a pitchfork someone had found. The tines could lift chunks of ice out. He began digging with the others, widening the hole.

“Stop!”

The voice halted them and everyone froze as one. The young man leapt into the hole. Without looking he seized a spade.

“He’s a foot down. Give me some room!”

Gamel stood back and watched. Carefully, quickly, the young man dug. He paused, and then shoved away more snow. Then he lifted something out of the ground.

“Siccy!”

Gamel recognized Sic, one of the boys who belonged to the mother. She rushed forwards, and then screamed again.

“He’s not breathing.”

The young man—Laken, that was his name—was calm. Or rather, he wasn’t panicking. He shouted at the woman.

“Move back! Get me a clear space above!”

Hands pulled him and the still boy out of the hole. Gamel watched, numb horror in his chest. The boy was dead. But Laken wasn't done yet.

"Breathe into his mouth. Like this. Steady breaths."

He was doing something, showing the woman something. Then he put his hands on the boy's chest and began to pump, as if he was trying to push something back into the child.

"Compressions. Place your hand on his chest like this. Now—"

The woman breathed and Laken pressed on his chest. Gamel watched without hope. Nothing was going to happen. This was no spell or [Healer]'s Skill. It was just air and some weird motion. It couldn't—

The boy *gasped*. He choked and his eyes flew open. The mother fell backwards, but then she *shrieked* and threw herself at her son. Gamel stared. His eyes stung as the boy breathed again.

"Give him air!"

Laken forced the mother back a bit. Then he stood up and ran to another body being pulled out of the snow. Gamel followed. Laken showed the rescuers what to do.

"Five minutes. If they don't wake up by then—"

It didn't work. Gamel stared at the cold body of the girl he'd always thought was too ugly to dance with and felt a hole open up in his chest. Laken moved on. The next body they brought up was cold as well, and Laken didn't even bother with it. The next was also dead. The next was alive and the woman clung to Laken even as he shouted.

The dead couldn't be brought back so easily. But the breathing and compressions—helped. It gave people hope and they tried it until Laken told them it was too late. It was a last-ditch effort he said; they were already dead. It was too late.

But it worked. Once, twice. Out of the many casualties, Gamel saw two cough up ice and snow and breathe again. A child, practically blue and still bleeding, opened her mouth and wailed after her breath had stopped. A young man inhaled, and nearly choked again as his family threw their arms around him.

And many who came out of the ground were still alive. They had clung to life, trapped in tiny places, hoping, begging silently for rescue. And it came, with precise accuracy and no shortage of willing hands. Gamel dug to save people trapped like him. He threw away the pitchfork and grabbed a

proper shovel when one was found. He dug and pulled out his best friend, the [Blacksmith].

His father.

Gamel stared down at the empty gaze and snow-covered beard. Snow hadn't filled his lungs like the others. But his neck had snapped as he had tumbled. It was twisted the wrong way.

The young man reached down with trembling hands. He had to fix it. He tried to turn his father's head back the right way. Gently at first, and then with more strength. It was no good. He felt something *shifting* beneath his hands and stumbled away to vomit.

When he was choking and wiping at his mouth, someone touched his shoulder. Gamel spun, and looked into closed eyelids.

Laken only held his shoulder. He had never met Gamel's father. He didn't know the man. But he looked in Gamel's eyes with his sightless ones and said only one thing:

"There are more people to save."

So Gamel left his father on the ground. He dug and dug until his hands blistered and bled and pulled up more bodies. A little girl who'd always gotten on his nerves. Dead. A husband who everyone knew beat his wife. Alive. He was sobbing like Gamel had been and he dug with his bare hands to pull his living spouse out of the ground with their dead baby in her hands.

There was no sense to it. No justice. There were only places where the cold hand of fate had taken lives, and miracles where that boundary had not been crossed.

Yet with every second they spent under the snow, the villagers would have died. And there were so many. If the others had been digging with no idea where they were, how many would have died?

But Laken pointed and the villagers were found. Within the hour, everyone had been found, and for a miracle, the living outnumbered the dead. Those who were alive were injured yes, some badly. They were all close to or frostbitten in places, and many were exhausted from digging. They were homeless. Hungry.

But they were alive. And though Gamel's hands bled, he held the girl who he'd dreamed of marrying as she cried and the [Midwife] bandaged her bleeding leg.

They were alive. Gamel had to keep wiping away tears, and his nose was stuffed. He didn't care.

They were *alive*. After the last body had come up, the villagers just sat on the snow, crying, tending to injuries, hugging each other. Being alive.

Somehow, there was even food. The half-Tr—Durene had brought food with her at the blind man's orders. And there was cloth to bandage wounds, even! As more and more hands were free, Laken directed them to dig up stores of food, buried in store rooms and cellars.

Gamel hadn't seen Durene before now. He'd been too busy digging. But he saw her tossing a massive amount of snow as she continued to dig, tirelessly.

Part of him was afraid of her. Part of him could still remember the Troll and the way the adults had been so frightened of her. Part of him remembered throwing things at the Troll-girl when he saw her. He saw her dig up food to hand around and the countless people she had saved by herself, and part of him felt ashamed.

Laken didn't just know where the bodies were. He found root cellars, and knew which ones were the most well-stocked. He had them dug up, and immediately had the food passed around to the starving people.

The food was meant to last a family the entire winter, but no one said a word, even if it was their stocks being opened and shared. Or rather, who would even think about something like that right now?

They were alive. That was all that mattered.

Gamel tore at some frozen bread someone had warmed up and saw there was a fire going. Someone was making a soup out of vegetables, but Gamel could have eaten the loaf with only snow and dirt as seasoning. He shared the frozen piece with the girl sitting next to him and stood up.

Laken was standing in the center of the village, still ordering people about. He wasn't shouting—his voice was hoarse and raw and the—Durene was standing next to him anxiously. Gamel hesitated, and then brought Laken a bowl of soup when it was done.

"Thank you."

The blind man took the bowl and thanked Gamel. But that was all wrong. Gamel's throat closed up. He had to say it.

"Thank you."

That was all he could say. What he had to say. Other villagers heard Gamel and came over. They said different things, used different words.

Some hugged Laken. Others found more food, kissed him, just cried. They all meant the same thing.

Thank you.

I pulled up dead people. I pulled up living people. Now, I can barely move my arms to lift the spoon. But I eat because I have to. I have to keep going. There's tragedy around me, but if I stop to stare at it I've made a mistake. My heart's too busy beating to stop and weep. That's how it should be.

"Anyone who can—we need houses."

The snow is so *deep*. But I'm already thinking about tonight. The villagers—they're all out, living and dead. And while the dead will keep for a while, the living are freezing. And it's going to be dark and cold tonight. It's barely mid morning despite the herculean efforts of the day, but we need to get as many houses out as possible.

"Durene, can you start clearing snow out over here? There's a barn—if we empty it, we could have a place for everyone to sleep at least."

I look at Durene, although I can't see her. But I can sense her, and touch her, and feel her beside me. That's more than enough. I know she has to be tired, but she doesn't show any of her exhaustion.

"I can do that. If someone helps get rid of the snow..."

"Is there anything better than a shovel? Pickaxes, maybe?"

Do they even have those? A young man hovering by me—the one who gave me the bowl of soup—offers a suggestion.

"What about magic?"

"Magic?"

I'm caught totally off-guard. But as it turns out, the young man knows a very weak flame spell. And so do other people in the village! It's a bit better than digging, but not by much.

"Hold off on it. Wait until we dig out a building and then you'll defrost it."

I keep ordering people about. They obey as if it's natural and I don't question it. They need a leader. And I'm the best choice.

Only I can sense the entire village. It's almost all under the snow, but I can sense which houses are intact, which ones have valuable items, and

most importantly, which are closest to the surface. It is like a game, and I organize people as best I can.

What's the first and most important thing? The elements. There's already a small fire going.

"Get someone with wood chopping skills and find some trees! I want two—no, four big fires going!"

Those with fire magic can light what wood we have. That's not enough of course. I ask around and find who might have the most clothes. We get that excavated and blankets, clothing—all go to children and those with injuries first. Bandages come from recycled cloth first boiled and dried by a fire.

What else? While I'm doing that I wonder about animals. I look—but they're all dead. We dug up the people first. Still, I know where they are. All of that is frozen food that can be retrieved later.

"Mister Laken? Emperor Laken?"

A voice. I turn. Prost is standing before me, humble.

"Emperor?"

I sense him bowing his head.

"Yes sir. Durene's dug up a good part of the barn, but she says it's not stable."

"Damn."

I couldn't tell when it's all buried.

"Can it be fixed? Who has skills in...carpentry?"

People around me provide answers. I choose three of the best builders to take a look at the building. Someone calls out to me. One of her sons—a teenager—was injured badly. His foot was broken. It needs to be set, but the [Midwife] has no potions.

I find some. By that point several people are telling me they need weapons. For Durene?

No. For wolves and monsters that might attack the injured. I find a sword buried deep and cast about. Broken bows...I find a few locations and have people start digging.

People ask me whether they should cook more soup. I ask and find out what the best recipes are. I direct them to a dead cow.

More work. It's getting dark apparently—I can feel the chill on my skin and the feeling of sunlight is gone. People need light, but torches are in

short supply. And the team working on the barn and other buildings don't want the badly-directed torchlight to mess with their work.

I have an idea.

"Wait a second."

I pull out a rectangle of metal. It's always in my pocket although I haven't turned it on until now. I push the power button.

"Siri? Turn on flashlight."

"Sorry, but I'm not able to do that."

People around me exclaim in awe, but I just scowl. I have to find the flashlight app buried among the various ones I've downloaded and press it manually. I *hate* doing that.

Then again, I don't exactly need a flashlight app, do I? It was put on my iPhone as a joke by my best friend. After Zoe installed it on my iPhone she told me it would help other people if they got lost, since I can find my way around in the dark just like the light. It would make them feel better, she told me.

And now? My iPhone glows with light. I can't tell, but people around me are shouting 'magic'. I give it to Prost and show him how to use it.

"Can I really use an artifact like this?"

"Just don't drop it."

I smile and turn away. The iPhone's batteries probably don't have that much juice in them in this cold, but the light helps. Prost and the others find the fault they're looking for and fix it.

"Laken."

Durene has the iPhone in her hands. I turn from having more blankets dug up and take it back from her.

"Thanks, Durene."

"Is that the 'phone' you were talking about?"

"It is. Does it look interesting to you?"

I can't imagine how the screen and the display looks to someone who's never seen a light bulb. There's awe in Durene's voice.

"Yes. It's like a star is in your hands."

A star? I smile.

"Would you like to use it?"

"Me? No! I would never dare. What if I broke it? I've never seen magic like that before."

"This is no magic. Anyone can use it. Here."

In the lull of the night as the immediate worries of the villagers are temporarily alleviated, I show Durene how to work the controls.

“You see that little triangle at the bottom? Press it. Now—”

Durene jumps as music begins to play from the iPhone. I take it from her and turn up the volume. Heads turn. I walk towards the villagers, holding a glowing star in my hands that sings with a woman’s voice. I walk among them, reassuring, checking on the wounded, finding things for those with energy to do. They’re warm, fed, alive. For some reason they still keep thanking me.

I keep walking, and a woman sings about love in French, a language none of the villagers know. But her haunting voice brings life to a frozen world. So the villagers listen to *L’hymne à l’amour* as their loved ones lie in the falling snow. And they cry although they don’t know what the song is about.

And at the same time, they know what the song is. The singer conveys all they need to know. When the song ends I check the battery. Durene sees a single digit and a red sliver of a bar. So I play one last song.

It’s not a song about love. It’s not even in French. It’s a song about family and home and regret. A man called Reinhard Mey sings in German, *Viertel vor Sieben*, a song never heard before in this world. And that too speaks to the villagers.

The last echoes of the song die out. I turn off the iPhone and find a place to sleep. There’s already a space cleared for me, and Durene as well to my surprise. We could have gone back to the cottage—we will, if only to pick up Frostwing. But for now I sit, and find once I’m sitting that I’m out of energy.

I put my head down and I’m out like a light in moments. I rest and the villagers around me live another night, crying themselves to sleep. And I am still an [Emperor] when I wake up.

[Emperor Level 9!]

[Skill – Empire: Blessing of the Hearth Obtained!]

Day 42

When I woke up, I felt rested. Which is odd considering that I woke up just after six in the morning. I know I got substantially less than six hours of

sleep considering how late I worked. But that was probably due to the Skill I received.

A skill for an empire. That's the only way I can look at it. And the blessing—it's powerful, I know that.

Most of the villagers did indeed sleep in the barn Durene helped dig up with the rest of the villagers. It was the best choice. And though my beautiful and courageous friend kept working after that, even Durene has her limits. A few more houses were uncovered and more bodies fit in there, but most slept in cramped conditions in a patched-up building surrounded by snow.

Under such conditions, where no fire could be lit and most of the heat came from blankets and body heat, you could normally expect a lot of discomfort. But that night the grieving slept like logs and woke up just as refreshed as me. And better—they were healed by their rest!

Somehow, minor cuts had scabbed over and healed almost overnight. The larger injuries weren't gone—but neither were they as bad as yesterday.

"It's totally overpowered."

That was my only comment when Durene told me about the healed people. It must be that I can only have one blessing, or that only one empire skill will work at the same time. Or...maybe [Emperors] are just that powerful.

Regardless, everyone knows it was due to me. The villagers woke up and made breakfast—helped change bandages—they're self-sufficient and intelligent. But they all look to me as I sit with Durene, eating some soup greasy with fat and chunks of meat.

Here's an irony: because all the animals were killed in the avalanche, the villagers are now eating a meaty broth, a rare treat for them in the winter or any other time, really. The warm, rich food warms my chest.

I look around and find that eyes are on me. I can feel them, even if I can't see them. Plus, Durene lets me know.

For once, the gazes aren't filled with petty concerns about Durene. I haven't heard a bad word for her since I took charge, and indeed, no one's busy enough to get into quarrels over anything except how to do things more efficiently.

After some thought, I stand up. I don't make a speech. I don't talk about yesterday, or my class. People have heard what I said; word gets around even in a disaster situation. But I still don't mention it.

I turn towards the doors. I know the bodies are still out there. And the houses are still buried in the snow. Scavengers are going to come soon, if they haven't already. The dead need to be buried with respect, and I'm still worried about monster attacks.

"Let's get to work."

So saying, I walk towards the doors. And the villagers follow me without question. Durene's walking by my side, and I'm comforted by her. She whispers to me.

"I leveled up. Five times!"

"Oh?"

"And I got two Skills! *Two!*"

"Good."

I don't smile. There's still so much to do, and there's been too much loss for that. But I keep walking forwards. Riverfarm needs all the help it can get. And it is mine now. My responsibility.

I feel sunlight on my skin. I look up, and know every inch and crevice of the village. I walk forwards, ignoring hands reached out to help me along. In this place I am even more sure-footed than people with sight. And it occurs to me, that despite all the things I've been through, I have been so lucky since I came to this world.

In little over a month I found someone to love. I found a way to see without seeing, I obtained a noisy pet, and I was in the right place to help save lives. I might have even changed a few minds about judging the girl who walks beside me.

Back home I was happy in my own way. But here I can see. Here I have a purpose. So as I walk and begin ordering people about, I wonder. Is this world meant for me? Is this destiny or chance? And is there any way I could possibly one day call this place...?

Home?

I don't know. But I'll take it all one day at a time. As I am. Not Laken, but Laken Godart, Emperor of the Unseen. Protector of Durene's Cottage. Ruler of Riverfarm Village.

[Emperor].

3.13 E

Maybe it's the wine talking, but I don't think Reynold the [Butler]'s such a bad guy. I mean, sure, he's a bit uptight and he's in the employ of a woman who might soon kill or torture me, but Reynold? He's got class.

It's probably the alcohol. But in my defense, I've downed over half a bottle by myself. Not much of a defense I'll grant you, but my nerves are still shaking.

Almost literally. I sit at the head of Magnolia's magical carriage, staring at the sleet and snow blasting around us and shudder again.

Goblins.

It feels like just a moment ago they were about to dice us up. In truth, it's been more like twenty minutes. And I'm still not over it.

Neither is Reynold. The poor carriage driver sits hunched in his seat. The wine – courtesy of the empty bottle I tossed a while back – fortified us both. But neither of us are exactly happy.

Maybe that's why we chat a bit as we keep going towards Invrail, and Magnolia Reinhart's mansion. Not about anything in particular; we talk just to keep ourselves from thinking. But I do learn something really interesting, and so does he.

"You met Erin?"

"You know Miss Solstice, Miss Griffin?"

We stare at each other. I had no idea. I mean, I know Erin mentioned meeting Lady Magnolia. She told me a lot about her encounter and of course I grilled her on the details, but did she mention a [Butler]?

...Crap. I think she might have. But of course I wouldn't have paid attention to that. And did she mention his name? Was it Reynold?

I have a bad feeling this might have been one of the things I ignored about her story. Idiot! But Reynold seems just as impressed in his way that I know Erin.

"She did mention you, Miss. I gather she was worried about your safety, but I hardly realized you two were on such good terms."

"It's odd, isn't it?"

I sigh as I stare across the frozen landscape. God. I wish she was here. She met Magnolia Reinhart and came away without a scratch somehow.

Erin might be annoying at times, thoughtless, but I'd rather have her as I'm about to enter the lair of the beast than not.

And when she told me all she'd been through—I clench my hand as I remember. She told me about Magnolia, and I flipped out at her. I got into a fight with her! True, I'd just lost some fingers, but I should have been more understanding.

Regrets. I ride on with Reynold and try to answer his questions as I think about what's going to happen next. Will I die? Or will I get a chance to convince Lady Magnolia that—what? I'm on the same side as she is?

That's what she told Erin. But I don't know if I can believe that. I'm damn sure that I can't trust her or anyone with the knowledge of how to make guns. But how do I get out of this with my skin intact?

I have a few ideas. The first of which is drinking from the second wine bottle I got Ressa to pass up to us. Ivolethe greedily slurps down the rich wine as she sits next to me. It's actually sort of disgusting the more I look at her, but it's one of those things I can't take my eyes off of. She's drunk at least three times her body weight already, I swear, but she doesn't even seem daunted by the sheer physical impossibility of it. She just keeps drinking happily, and singing some song that might be in Celtic.

“Miss, I wonder if I could have a word?”

Reynold's voice breaks me out of my thoughts. I look over to him.

“What's that?”

He hesitates, and casts a look back towards the carriage behind him. I look too—Ressa's closed the hatch separating us. Reassured, Reynold speaks to me, but quietly, and I scoot over to listen.

“I know Lady Reinhart has requested your presence, just as she has the other...people from your world.”

Gods. He knows. But Reynold doesn't seem bothered by that. He's frowning, and I can tell he's thinking something over. Anything to help me out. I listen as he comes to a decision.

“It's true her methods may seem sudden to people who do not know her —”

I snort.

“That's an understatement. Kidnapping me out of a city is normal, is it?”

To my surprise Reynold's lips twitch.

“More than you might think. No one gainsays a member of the Five Families, least of all Magnolia Reinhart. And it’s true that Lady Reinhart demands much. I know you have your issues with her. But...”

“But?”

Reynold hesitates. He looks again back towards the carriage. Ressa hasn’t said anything since the Goblins. Reassured, he continues talking. Even so, he lowers his voice to a whisper. I practically have to put my ear to his lips to hear him over the rushing wind.

“She is not a bad woman, Miss Ryoka. Driven, yes, but she cares deeply for the fate of her servants and all those living on this continent. If you can create even one of the wonders the others from your world claim—”

“Reynold. Stop talking.”

Both Reynold and I jump in our seats. He twists in his seat, face pale. But the window into the carriage is still closed. I stare at the closed door in amazement. We’re still going at top speed, and the wind is blasting around us. It’s hard just to hear Reynold’s voice, but Ressa was *inside* the coach.

She heard that? Is it another [Ninja] skill? Or [Assassin]?

What is she?

I have no idea. But her words are enough to scare Reynold witless. He grips the reins of the carriage in a death grip and refuses to talk, no matter what I try. So the rest of the ride passes in silence. But the entire while I’m thinking.

Magnolia. What does she want? She claims not to want to use technology from my world. But I don’t believe her. So what should I do? Help her? Do I have a choice?

How do I get myself out of this one? I’ve got...one option? Two. Mm... maybe three. Three ways to get out of this mess.

Fighting isn’t one of those options. Aside from the fact that I’m pretty sure Ressa is a better fighter than I am, I know how influential Magnolia Reinhart is. Even if by some miracle I ran away, she could have every adventurer, city guardsman and assassin on the continent after me in a heartbeat.

No, I’ve got to talk my way out of this. I just wish I was confident in my ability to do so. So I sit in the cold, apprehensive, trying to bring out all the intelligence, all the wit I have.

But I am afraid. If I were the me of a month ago, I might be so cocksure and brave to think I can get out of this no matter what happens. But now—

The carriage slows. I sit up instantly and see something appear out of the white background. A mansion, guarded by high walls and a single gate.

“The manor of Magnolia Reinhart.”

That’s all Reynold says as he drives us through the gates. They swing open instantly as we approach, but I see no gatekeeper. Automatic magical gates?

Yeah. Why not? But then my cynicism is lost as I stare at the mansion.

“Oh wow.”

Erin told me a bit about Magnolia’s mansion, but I was mainly focusing on what Magnolia wanted of her and me. She told me about the magic—

But this is something else.

A whale swims across the front of the house, gliding across the stone as if it were a sea. A line of metal giants, suits of armor with empty visors, stand at attention, flanking the entrance. And a cloud floats through the suddenly clear skies overhead. Even the air is warmer, and as I step outside the coach, I suddenly feel warm in my clothes.

It’s suddenly spring again. A cool breeze blows, and I look around and find a group of men and women attired in servant’s clothing are standing with the Golems. I hop off the front of the carriage and feel my cramped legs protesting. I stare awkwardly at the servants. Well, what do I do? Reynold’s sitting in the front seat, quiet. But what about these other servants?

Are they a welcoming committee? For me? Is Magnolia Reinhart really

—

“Welcome back, Miss Ressa.”

Fuck. They scared the ever living *crap* out of me. All of the servants speak at once as they bow towards the carriage. I look back and see Ressa stepping down from the side of the carriage as Reynold holds the door open.

Now here’s a contrast. She’s dressed like a maid, but she descends and walks past me like a queen. Of course, I was taught proper posture and etiquette when I was young, but I didn’t take much to it.

But Ressa? Ressa could fill in for the Queen of England any time she wanted. I feel like an idiot as I watch her walk ahead of me. Ressa takes a look at the gathered household staff and begins giving orders like a general.

“Teresa, Bener, tell the others to prepare more refreshments for our guests. Ryoka Griffin will be meeting with Lady Magnolia at once. Eve, a

pot of tea. Reynold—”

She turns to the [Butler] and I see him bowing his head.

“—Have the carriage inspected for damage. Then I want you to test the spell lattice. If the wards are damaged, schedule an appointment to have them recast. The [Invisibility Field] should not have cut out from a mere unenchanted bolt.”

“At once, Miss Ressa.”

Reynold hurries back to the coach as I stare. Wait, so that was an accident back there? I thought Rags just hit us to make us appear again, but something malfunctioned?

Ressa isn’t even slowing down. She keeps giving orders as people scurry away from us. I eye the imposing Golems. What are they for? To welcome her back? Or to restrain me?

It doesn’t look like I’m getting the red carpet welcome. I look at Ivolethe—she’s too busy flying into the suits of armor and laughing at them from the inside to pay attention.

“Pst. Ivolethe.”

The tiny faerie hears me. She flies back, opening her mouth to comment, but I shake my head at her warningly.

“Don’t speak. And don’t follow me into the manor. Just stay outside, okay? If you can, find out where I am. But don’t go inside. It’s dangerous —”

I break off and Ivolethe flies away from me as Ressa turns her head to stare at me. She doesn’t beckon, but I can tell she wants me to come over to her.

I fold my arms and wait. Like hell I’m taking orders from her. Ressa frowns slightly; then she looks up and sighs.

I look up too. I see only darkness overhead, and then a drop of water hits me right in the eye. As I curse I realize the cloud Erin told me about—the one normally circling Magnolia’s garden—is right overhead. And even as I think that, I feel the cloud open up overhead.

Rain begins pouring down on my head, instantly drenching me. And only me. The cloud seems determined to shower me, and I sprint towards the mansion, swearing a blue streak as I reach shelter.

Instantly, the rain stops. I stand, dripping, in the lush interior of a mansion that would put Versailles to shame, and see a gaggle of [Maids], [Manservants], [Butlers], and other staff staring wide-eyed at me.

I hear footsteps, and turn to see Ressa walk in behind me. There's not a drop of water on her clothing. She looks down her nose at me as I drip onto the marble flagstones. As if it's my fault I just got *rained on* in the *winter*.

"Your damn Mistress did that, didn't she?"

Ressa makes no response. But her lips do twitch as if she's suppressing a smirk.

"A towel will be provided for you shortly. Lady Magnolia will see you personally. If you will follow me?"

Without another word she begins striding off down the corridor. I stare at her back, but I've got no choice. Either I follow her, or I bet something else happens. One of the Golems will start beating me to death, maybe.

I follow her, walking fast to keep up. A [Maid] appears by my side and offers me a towel. I snatch it, dry myself, and hurl it into the face of a passing [Butler]. He drops whatever he was holding and I storm on. If they're not going to play nice, neither am I.

Okay, that last bit from me was an overreaction. That man didn't deserve that, and the look I get from Ressa isn't pleasant to say the least. But I'm only now realizing that this is happening.

I'm going to meet Lady Magnolia. Not a minute after I got out of the carriage. She's not going to give me any time to collect myself or prepare. And she's going to surprise me and try to catch me off guard any way she can to get the upper hand.

Like that just now. Seriously? Making a cloud rain on me? That's juvenile. But as a way to keep me off balance, it definitely worked.

Ressa pauses and turns left down a large corridor. She stops before a set of double doors and looks at me reprovingly.

"Lady Magnolia awaits you, Ryoka Griffin."

Just that? No warnings? No hints about what's going to happen? I take a deep breath.

Crap. This isn't good. I can tell my nerves are still rattled. And an internal check tells me I'm not only a bit drunk, but I could really use a catnap.

But there's no helping it. I'm in the lion's den. Or is it Dragon's den? Bah. I'd rather go up against Teriarch in another riddle game than Magnolia.

And then Ressa pulls open the doors. She steps inside, and I follow her. I stare around an inordinately pink room, looking out over the main area of

the manor. We're on the second floor? When did we get up here?

It's decorated sparsely for such a lavish room. Aside from the huge windows looking out, there are only two couches and a tea table in the center. I'm sure other furniture used to be here, but now the room is empty save for that. It makes everything feel larger, and somehow more oppressive at the same time.

My eyes find a small pot of steaming tea on the table. I see the empty couch, and then my eyes travel to look at the other occupant of the room, the woman whom Ressa now stands behind.

And then—there she is. Sitting on a plush couch in the center of the room. Poised, elegant, calm and collected. Holding a tea cup in one hand and staring directly at me.

Lady Magnolia.

My breath catches in my chest for a second. This is too sudden. I haven't prepared, haven't steeled myself—

But here she is. And it's too late to slow down, because Magnolia comes out guns blazing.

"Ryoka! So good to see you again!"

Her bright, cheerful voice nearly gives me a heart attack. I'd almost forgotten—but now I remember. Lady Magnolia. For all you might hear of her wealth, power, and influence, in person she's quite energetic.

Disarmingly so. Magnolia beckons me to the couch. I hesitate, but then walk over and take a seat. Across from me, the noblewoman beams, the very picture of delight. I keep my eyes on her face.

Remember, she's not nearly as naïve and innocent as she seems. She acts like Erin, but she's not. Be on your guard—

"Can I offer you anything? Tea? Biscuits? A knife to the throat? How would you feel most comfortable?"

What? I freeze in my seat. Magnolia laughs lightly as she studies my face. Her eyes are sharp; she watches me like a cat studying a mouse.

"Please, Miss Ryoka. You practically ooze wariness. Even if I did not have my [Sense Intentions] Skill—which I do and am quite adept at using—I would be able to tell how tense you are. Relax, my dear. You are not in danger. Yet."

Mind games. Right off the bat. She's not even pretending—not that I'd believe her—damn. I blink, try to catch my balance. What's my response here?

“I’m not thirsty.”

Brilliant, Ryoka. You’re really showing off your debating skills right now. Dad would be so proud. I grit my teeth and stare at the tea pot. Magnolia raises her eyebrows. She glances up at Ressa and shrugs.

“At least you weren’t foolish enough to ask if the tea is poisoned. Honestly, why would anyone waste good tea like that?”

“I can think of a few reasons.”

“Really? It must be terrible, being so paranoid so young. Don’t you think, Ressa?”

“Indeed.”

Behind Lady Magnolia, the maid nods briefly. I stare at her.

“Thanks for sending your maid to personally escort me. I was touched.”

“Think nothing of it, please. It would have been so inconvenient if you’d fled, and Ressa did manage to protect you from those Goblins, after all.”

Lady Magnolia chuckles about that, as if Goblin armies are a regular occurrence. Which...is actually not that far from the truth. I stare at her.

“And the rain cloud? Your handiwork as well?”

“A greeting. I know it was a naughty prank; I couldn’t resist. Do forgive me.”

And there’s no way to turn it on her. I could...what? Get angry? Pursue the issue? We haven’t even gotten down to the brass tacks yet. I move on.

“And you made time to see me right away. I must be so important.”

Across from me, Lady Magnolia sips from her tea and smiles.

“Well, some might think so. Myself, I was just bored of meeting stuffy dignitaries. I needed some entertainment, so I cancelled my discussion with one of my visitors to see you.”

“How...kind.”

She twinkles at me, all flowers and blades hidden in the petals.

“Isn’t it? I did consider letting you wait for a few hours while I attended to other business, but I feared you might run off again if I did.”

“No fear. I’m not stupid enough to run.”

“Really?”

And there it is again! The woman wears the most bland expression possible as she delivers a damn good retort. I just stare at her for a second. The Magnolia I’m used to dealing with did *not* act like this. Why is she taking the gloves off so early?

Regain the flow of the conversation. I glance at the tea pot. There's an empty cup and saucer. I reach for it and pour myself a cup. Ressa and Magnolia watch me, one disapprovingly, the other amused.

"Thirsty? My dear, let Ressa do that for you. She is a [Maid]."

"And a [Ninja]."

I mutter as I fill my teacup. Magnolia laughs again.

"A [Ninja]? You think Ressa has a [*Ninja*] class?"

She sounds delighted. I stare at her as she turns and laughs in Ressa's face.

"Ressa, did you hear that?"

"I did, milady."

"A [Ninja]! Wouldn't that be quite amazing to see? If I bought you some dark clothing, would you hang from the ceiling and jump out of the shadows to fill my cup?"

The Lady Reinhart practically chokes on her drink as she giggles. I just stare at her, and then realize Ressa's giving me a death glare. Um. Looks like I was mistaken.

"So she's *not* a ninja."

"Oh please. Does Ressa look like an islander to you? [Assassins] are the class of choice here; a [Ninja] would be a completely different culture!"

Magnolia snorts as she takes a deep drink of tea. I cautiously do likewise. I'm pretty sure the cup isn't poisoned—why bother if I'm here and she can just do whatever she wants by force? But—

The instant my tongue touches the tea, it practically goes numb. Poison? I nearly spit out the liquid before I realize what I'm tasting.

Sugar. It's practically liquid *sugar*! I don't know how many sugar cubes died to make the tea this sweet—all I know is that I've tasted sodas that weren't nearly this bad for your health. Instantly I put the cup down.

"What is this filth?"

Lady Magnolia frowns at me as I make a face and shove the tea cup back onto the table. Not gently either; a bit slops over the side at which point I'm sure it adhered to the table like glue.

"Well now, how rude! That is perfectly good tea, Miss Ryoka. And it is not poisonous in the slightest."

I scrub at my tongue with my teeth before I reply.

"It might as well be poison. There's way too much sugar in that pot!"

"She's right about that."

Ressa interjects, voice disapproving. Magnolia glances up at her in clear irritation and drinks from her own cup. It's got to be the same tea—she's drinking it like water! And pouring herself another cup!

"You two don't understand my passions at all. You're too much like Ressa, dear Ryoka."

That's an insult. Ressa and I exchange a glance and then I go back to staring at Magnolia. Once she's done filling up her own cup, she sighs.

"Well, that's enough mindless chatter for now."

She looks at me suddenly, and it's as if the mask she was wearing, the smiling noble [Lady]—suddenly falls off. All at once I feel pressure in the room, a hot, stifling gaze that sends a chill throughout my body fixing me in place.

This is the true face of Lady Magnolia. But she doesn't leap at me and tear my eyes out. She just keeps speaking, in that calm, level voice.

"It has been a long time since we last saw each other, hasn't it?"

It's hard to speak, but I force my tongue to work.

"I guess. It's only been about a month? Two?"

"Mm. But so much can happen in so short a time. As I'm sure you're aware in your profession."

Lady Magnolia nods at me. She extends a pinkie and points at my right hand with it.

"I see you have lost something."

I blink at her and then remember. My fingers. They suddenly ache and burn with the reminder of their absence. I realize I'm clenching my hand and relax it.

There's something almost like sympathy in the other woman's gaze as she looks at me.

"A harsh price to pay. Did you lose it on a delivery?"

"Yes."

She nods as there's nothing more to say than that.

"You have gone through much, if what I suspect is correct. I know for a fact that you are richer—are you wiser as well, I wonder?"

I don't respond. I just cross my arms—hiding my stumps under my other arm—and wait. She's leading the conversation; I'll let her get to the point.

"Hmm."

Lady Magnolia doesn't seem bothered by my silence. She taps her ring finger on the cup as she stares at me.

"I trust you've met Erin Solstice? She was quite a feisty young woman, but I was pleased to meet her, if only briefly."

No response. I say not a word.

"And Teriarch? I do know you met him. How is the old fool doing? He did mention you to me, you know. Apparently you had a rather interesting conversation."

Just wait. She's trying to lure me into conversation. Magnolia eyes me again.

"So, do you have any theory as to why you are here? Any suspicions? Or am I simply the villain in your uncomplicated view of the world?"

My lips are sealed. Magnolia sighs, exasperated.

"Very well, I suppose I should spell it out for you. You are here because I wish to talk to you. And I sent Ressa because you have a habit of refusing to listen to other people. So you have come all this way to have a conversation, with me, Lady Magnolia."

I just stare at her. I can keep silent. I've had teachers, principals, police officers, and my parents all shouting at me. I can stonewall.

Magnolia keeps chattering, though.

"I do enjoy talking. You see, when two people meet, it is customary for them to talk. I understand this may be difficult in your case, and perhaps it is an imposition on your limited mental faculties. However, the custom is that when one person says something—we call this a statement, the other person says something as well, usually in the same vein of topic. This is what we call a reply—"

"I get it. I'll talk."

I have a feeling she could do that all day if I didn't interrupt. Magnolia stops talking and stares at me. Without saying another word.

Great, she's waiting for me to reply. I roll my eyes, but now the full intensity of her stare is on me. Multiplied by Ressa's death gaze. Great. I take a breath, and launch into things.

"I guess you've gotten the letter I sent you."

"Letter?"

For a second Magnolia blinks, then her eyes widen.

"Oh, the letter! Yes, I'd nearly forgotten about that!"

"You did?"

That's odd. I thought this all stemmed from the letter I sent Lady Magnolia by way of Valceif a while ago. I'd expected an immediate response back then, and I'd been prepared to negotiate—

But Lady Magnolia just waves her hand as if that's ancient history.

"Oh yes, your cryptic little hint that was supposed to intrigue me enough to pursue you. I recall that. It was quite interesting—I wonder, what did you hope to gain from talking with me?"

I'm not sure. It was so long ago—so long and not so long ago. I hadn't gotten to know the faeries, and I was desperate for something to help both me and Erin.

Magnolia watches my expression, and although I'm sure my face doesn't change, I know she's reading my thoughts through that skill of hers. But even if she can do that, there's a way to beat that skill. Tell the truth.

"I'm not sure what I was thinking. But I was open to talking, back then."

"Indeed? No doubt you had your own goals. Perhaps you were thinking of selling me some secrets."

"Perhaps."

Yeah, that was probably it. Magnolia smiles enigmatically.

"And perhaps I would have taken you up on that offer. But alas, by the time your letter reached me I had already found other people like you. Thus, I had no need to keep searching for you."

And there it is. Part of the issue's out in the open at last. I breathe out.

"Yeah. The others. Erin told me you have other people from my world here."

Not a bat of an eyelid. Lady Magnolia smiles and shrugs.

"Oh yes. They are guests here, for as long as my patience allows. Pestilential, inconsiderate brats that they are, that might not be for too much longer."

Wow. That's something. I know Erin said Magnolia didn't like the others, but—

"Okay, so you have people from my world. You know everything. Why am I here, then?"

"Dead gods. Here we go again."

To my surprise, Lady Magnolia touches her eyes with one hand and sighs gustily. I stare at her. When she looks up, her irritation is suddenly plain across her face.

“She’s doing it, Ressa. I thought she wouldn’t—but she’s doing it.”

“Yes, milady.”

“First that girl Erin—are all young women from her world inbred, do you think?”

“Doing what?”

“There she goes again!”

Magnolia scowls at me and points accusingly at my chest as if I were some kind of monster.

“Stop asking thoughtless questions! I know you’re not that stupid, Miss Ryoka. Or at least, I hope you’re not because if I have to have *another* conversation like the one I had with Erin Solstice, I *will* throw this tea pot at you.”

What’s with her? It’s like a switch has flipped. Suddenly Magnolia Reinhart is all action and no pretense. She glares at me.

“A word of advice, Ryoka Griffin. Few things annoy me as much as feigned ignorance. Do not pretend you don’t know why you are here. You and I both know that I know almost everything. That you come from another world? Obvious. That your world has different technology and inventions? Of course! Your fellow travelers have told me all about the wondrous things of your world—phones, planes, guns, cars—and you know that I have a vested interest in such things.”

Lady Magnolia drinks more of the sugary liquid that vaguely resembles tea in her cup as she stares at me.

“I know everything. Everything except the details. You know, or you might have guessed that while your friends can chatter on to me about the wonders of guns and warfare as your world practices it, they are remarkably empty-headed when it comes to producing such miracles. It’s rather like having a boastful idiot claim to be able to fly without a shred of evidence to back it up. But you *do* know how to fly, don’t you, Ryoka Griffin?”

My lips clamp shut. Magnolia eyes me.

“Yes. You do. Or at least, you know more than the others. And you know that is why you are here, Ryoka. I want you to tell me what you know.”

The woman sighs, looking suddenly exhausted.

“So here we are. That skips—how much needless back-and-forth? Honestly, I was willing to play along for a while, but when you started acting like an idiot I lost my patience.”

I just look at her. This is Magnolia Reinhart? Is this her true face? Is she being honest with me for a reason or—

“Well? Say something!”

I barely see it coming. Magnolia flicks her wrist, and suddenly the saucer of the tea cup comes spinning at me. I catch it reflexively.

“What the—?”

“Don’t you dare ask what that was. It was a *saucer*. And I threw it at you because I am *irate*.”

I just stare at her. She’s *violent*! Is it the sugar working? No—this is a completely different approach. She’s doing this on purpose too! I’ll bet—she’s seized complete hold of the conversation.

Well—fine. Let’s just dive into this. No pretenses, no holds barred. I grit my teeth.

“Okay, let’s assume you’re right about everything. In that case, at what point do you strap me to the rack and torture me for information?”

“Torture? Oh, please. Why would I need torture when I can just use magic? Or a Skill?”

Magnolia snorts at me, but she seems mollified by my response. She takes something out of the pocket of her dress and peers at me. For a second I’m thrown—I didn’t even see the cunning pocket sewn into her dress. Well now, she’s not obeying medieval fashion standards with that.

But in her hands—what is that? A monocle? I instantly have a bad feeling about it, and it gets worse when she puts it to her eyes and...studies me.

Yeah, she’s looking at me. And that monocle—

Oh no. Is she reading my mind?

No—she couldn’t be. Think. My mind races as Magnolia peers at me. I’m...pretty sure she can’t read minds, even with an artifact. If she could, she’d wear that thing all the time. It’s definitely for revealing some aspect about me—a lie detector?

Don’t get thrown by it. I fold my arms and wait. But Magnolia seems satisfied. She tucks the monocle back in her secret pocket.

“Hmf. Now, as to getting you to spill your much-vaunted secrets. Tell me, do you really think it would be that difficult for me?”

I hesitate.

“Yes.”

“Really? How arrogant of you.”

Magnolia rolls her eyes in exasperation. She stares at me with a bit of contempt, or is it disappointment?

“You astound me, Ryoka Griffin. For someone who appears so intelligent—could it be you’ve forgotten my Skills? Surely not.”

She smiles at me, and every hair on the back of my neck tingles.

“I’m curious. What would you do, if I, oh, *asked you to tell me everything you know?*”

It’s like lightning. Pink lightning. The words hit me and go inside my head, effortlessly opening the vault of my mind. My mouth opens. I should tell her everything, right? Isn’t that the best—

No.

I waver, grit my teeth. I’ve felt this before. This...is like Teriarch’s geas spell! God—I *did* forget she could do this!

Magnolia smiles at me, and puts more intensity into her silken voice.

“Come now. You know you want to. This is quite simple for me—if you can’t even stop me from doing this, you are truly foolish. Tell me everything, Ryoka Griffin.”

I want to tell her. My jaw is clamped shut, but I can feel the muscles spasming. It’s taking all I’ve got to hold still. Magnolia’s waiting for me to crack. But—I—

I’ve done this before!

My mouth opens. But what comes out is a wordless shout. I jump up, fist flashing towards Magnolia’s face—

And find myself tumbling backwards onto the couch, ears ringing, pain bursting from my chest and cheek. Ressa’s standing in front of Lady Magnolia, hands raised. I reel backwards and sit down *hard* on the sofa.

“Um. Well, that was surprising.”

The only sound in the room comes from Lady Magnolia. I can see her blinking at me from behind Ressa. She looks as surprised as I’ve ever seen her. I sit on the couch, staring up at Ressa. I didn’t even see her *move*. I’m tempted to try and hit her, but—

“Very well, Ressa, please step aside.”

Lady Magnolia’s hands push at Ressa. The surprised [Maid] moves sideways. Lady Magnolia blinks a few more times, and then looks down at her lap.

“Spilled tea. How wasteful.”

A small pool of tea is puddled in her dress. It's ruining the expensive pink silk. But to my surprise, Magnolia just sighs and stands up. She shakes the dress—

And the tea slides off it and onto the carpet. I blink. Magnolia catches my eye and shrugs.

"Ward spells on the dress. Prevents staining. Too bad about the tea, though."

Then she sits down as if nothing has happened and pours herself more tea. I rub at my cheek as Ressa takes a place behind Magnolia again. She's staring at me hard, but I'm in no mood to fight.

Once there's a fresh cup of tea in her hands, Magnolia looks at her maid and then at me.

"That was a bit too quick for my eyes, Ressa my dear. Am I right in thinking you stopped her from pummeling me?"

"Yes, milady."

"I thought as much. Well, I seem to have misjudged you slightly, Ryoka my dear. I thought you might resist my Skill, but nothing as impressive as that. How did you do it, pray? You have no magical items on you—none for that purpose at any rate—and you have no Skills."

So the monocle was looking at that? I just stare at Magnolia and shrug.

"That's a secret."

"Hmf. Well, I'm not too curious so I won't pry. May I congratulate you, however? It isn't often that someone has directly struck at me. The last person to do it was, well, your friend, Erin Solstice."

Erin tried to hit Lady Magnolia? I just blink at her. Magnolia turns to Ressa.

"Didn't you take a teapot to the face that time?"

"It was to the chest, and it was lukewarm tea."

"Ah, of course."

I eye Ressa. The maid eyes me. I definitely feel like the mouse if we're in a cat and mouse relationship. She got in front of Magnolia from behind the couch before I could hit her. And she hit me in the cheek and chest in an instant.

"Your maid's quite dedicated."

That's code for 'what kind of freak of nature is your maid'? Magnolia just shrugs at me.

“Of course she is. Ressa possesses many skills, some of which include cleaning and pouring tea—others of which involve preventing people with blades from stabbing me.”

“And that’s normal for a [Maid]?”

“It’s normal for maids under *my* employ. Do you think I would carelessly walk around—even in my own home—and entertain guests without a bodyguard of some kind?”

“I suppose not.”

“But you didn’t think of it, did you? Really.”

Magnolia sighs and looks at her maid.

“They grow more simpleminded every year, it seems. Erin was like that, wasn’t she, Ressa? She was rather surprising in some ways, but she was as thoughtless as a rock in others.”

Okay, I feel like I should stand up for Erin even if what Magnolia’s saying is true. I grit my teeth and force myself to ignore the stinging pain in my chest and on my cheek.

“Erin is my friend.”

“How wonderful for you.”

Magnolia gives me a look that tells me she could care less. I keep going, ignoring her expression.

“She’s my friend. But I’ll admit she’s also an idiot in some ways. She doesn’t understand your goals. But I do. I know what you want, so let’s get to it.”

“Do you really?”

The other woman eyes me with more skepticism. She shrugs.

“Well then, go on. Enlighten me. What do I so desperately want from you?”

I open my mouth. Magnolia raises a finger.

“However—if you haven’t thought this through, Ressa will beat you *quite* black and blue.”

“What is your problem with stupid questions?”

I snap at Magnolia and barrel on before she can tell her maid to kick the crap out of me for that question.

“I know what you want. You know about my world by now. You’ve talked with people who’ve told you about guns, bombs, and all of our technology. I know you told Erin you don’t want that information spread,

but there's no way in hell you wouldn't want to manufacture those kinds of weapons for yourself."

"Really? And why is that?"

"Isn't it obvious? Fear. Even if no one in your world has weapons yet, what if you run into more people from my world? What if someone else creates guns in secret? If that happens, it's too late. You *need* to make weapons or else you'll be overwhelmed."

I don't know how Erin didn't consider that. For all Magnolia says she can suppress that technology—that's impossible. But to my surprise, Magnolia doesn't even bat an eyelash at my answer. Instead, she laughs.

"Good answer! Unfortunately—you are wrong, my dear Ryoka. Right in one way, but terribly wrong in the other."

What? I stare at Magnolia. She smiles at me, shaking her head.

"You really are new to this world, aren't you? I sometimes forget—but you really know nothing."

"What do you mean?"

I'm right. I'm sure of it. But Magnolia clearly thinks I'm wrong. She puts down her tea cup and stretches her fingers out.

"I'm sure you'd say I'm being overconfident. But the truth is, Ryoka Griffin, guns are nothing to fear if it's just a war we speak of. If one side has guns, they have an advantage, yes, but it does not mean they would necessarily win."

"You—clearly don't understand weapons from my world."

I shake my head, trying to explain to Magnolia how insane her claim is. One side with swords and arrows taking on an army with guns? I suppose if it were guerilla attacks and attrition warfare—but no, she's wrong!

"Oh? You disagree, Ryoka? Are guns really that fearsome?"

"Of course! They—"

I raise my voice in anger, trying to get Magnolia to understand, to be wary when I hear a slight knock. Instantly, I go silent. Magnolia frowns, and Ressa immediately turns her head to the door. Magnolia raises her voice and calls out.

"Yes?"

The door opens and a maid enters the room. She looks nervous, and nearly freezes up when she sees me, Ressa, and Lady Magnolia all staring at her. But she's clearly more afraid of doing her job wrong in front of Ressa, so she speaks quickly and clearly while bobbing a curtsy.

“I am extremely sorry to bother you, Lady Reinhart. But your guest—the Great Mage Nemor—requests the pleasure of speaking with you forthwith.”

Great Mage? Is that a class? But Magnolia just frowns, looking irritated.

“Tell him to go away. I’m busy.”

The maid hesitates. But when Ressa glares she immediately bobs a curtsy and closes the door. Magnolia turns back to me, frowning.

“Great Mage Nemor? That’s hardly accurate.”

“Is that someone important?”

My mind’s still on Magnolia’s outrageous claim, but I ask just in case. Magnolia snorts in idle amusement.

“He’s useful, but hardly important—or entertaining. He will wait. Now, go on. You were going to tell me how the armies of your world would destroy mine in an instant. Let’s assume you had an army – or simply the technology from your world. What would make them so fearsome?”

I glare at her. She’s so damn cavalier. Fine. She wants an explanation?

“A tank.”

“A tank? Oh, the others did mention one of them. A metal moving box that fires another type of gun, aren’t they?”

It sounds so simple when Magnolia says it. I shake my head as I try to explain.

“If an army had a tank—just one!—it would be able to destroy thousands of soldiers. A tank has armor that can withstand any number of spells you throw at it. It can hurl an explosion miles away that can demolish a building—”

“A spell can do the same.”

I pause. Magnolia stares at me, one eyebrow raised.

“Your tanks sound slow and cumbersome. Can they really beat a mage hiding in the grass with a [Grand Fireball] spell?”

Grand fireball? Could that destroy a tank? I—hesitate.

“That’s not the point! That’s one tank. But an army could have hundreds. And a mage takes years, decades to train. A soldier with a gun can shoot countless people and he only takes a few days to train. While a mage—”

“Hm. Yes. I see your point.”

Magnolia waves me into silence, not looking daunted in the least. She taps a fingernail on her dress, talking as she does.

“An army of tanks and guns, you say? I still find it hard to imagine, but I am told a gun is like a crossbow that shoots hundreds of bolts per minute, farther than any normal bow. Is that right?”

Pretty much. I nod. Magnolia nods as well.

“Fearsome indeed. But these are just arrows, aren’t they? Excuse me, ‘bullets’. Nonmagical bits of iron. Your...wonderful armies from your world—they lack magic. And that is a crucial flaw. Let us say you have, oh, ten thousand soldiers with guns and several tanks. And any number of your aircrafts as well.”

Magnolia leans over the coffee table, eyes glittering. Her smile has teeth.

“I could destroy an army like that in less than ten minutes.”

I believe her. I stare into Magnolia’s eyes, and I believe she could do it. How? A spell? Enchanted armor? Would enchanted armor even suffer dents? Could you really send a few warriors in plate mail and take down tanks that easily?

“You really don’t fear guns?”

“I didn’t say that.”

Magnolia frowns at me irately. She looks as if she’s considering tossing her tea cup at me and then shrugs and goes on.

“Anyone with half a brain knows that a gun is a dangerous weapon. But anyone with a full brain knows that even an army with guns is quite easy to destroy.”

“Oh really?”

“I will hit you, you know. Or rather, order Ressa to do it for me.”

Magnolia glares at me and sighs. She settles back into her seat.

“I can destroy two armies as easily as I can destroy one. That is not the issue.”

She raises one delicate finger.

“One gun, or even ten thousand will not change the world. But a million will.”

I think I get it. Magnolia nods as she goes on.

“I do not want to create guns and other such technologies. I do not want such secrets to spread either. And the reason for that is simple: while such devices might provide power to me in the short term, it will inevitably change the world for the worse. If every [Soldier] has a gun, then it is likely

the larger army will prevail. If a child can kill a man in full plate armor, then levels lose much of their meaning.”

“And if anyone can field an army, then you lose your power.”

Magnolia eyes me sternly, as if I’ve missed the point.

“*Everyone* loses. Don’t you understand? If it becomes an issue of numbers, then the most numerous races will conquer the others. If the balance of power is upset so far, then it will be a war where guns become the only meaningful value. As it is, an army with guns would be a significant threat, but one any world power would be able to deal with.”

She sighs.

“But only if it were an army. If guns were commonplace? In time, guns would dominate everything. In time. A nation able to manufacture more arms of a better quality would inevitably defeat the others. It will lead to a war to end all wars, where the victor will stand upon the corpses of all.”

My blood goes cold as I think of that kind of war. That’s what I envisioned as well. True, there might be ways to change such a war, but in the end it would just be an arms race, and countless battles where people with guns fight people with swords. A bloodbath.

Lady Magnolia seems to agree. She shakes her head.

“What a pointless war. It will occur if word of this technology spreads. A war with your world is one thing; if it occurs it will be inevitable. But if I can, I will prevent this world from seizing such dangerous weapons.”

Can I trust her? I don’t know. But Magnolia seems to have thought this through. She looks at me, and I feel the weight of her gaze pressing down on me, trying to force me to tell the truth, to speak.

“So, here is my most pressing question, one which I believe you will answer. How long will it take for these dangerous weapons to be developed? If one of the people from your world were to cooperate—or give up such information to a powerful individual or nation, how long would it take for them to engineer such inventions?”

The question catches me off guard. For a second I’m not sure if I should answer it. But from what Magnolia’s said—I do some quick calculations. I’m obviously not an expert in firearms, but let’s think about it rationally. If someone needed to find all the ingredients of gunpowder, sulfur, saltpeter, charcoal—and secure them as a long-term resource...testing...building prototypes...

“You could probably have a prototype gun ready in less than a month if you had a kingdom’s worth of resources at your disposal. But a gun that’s ready for war? A proper gun? An army? That would take years.”

The more dangerous route would be a cannon. That’s easier to make, honestly. I share that with Magnolia and she nods thoughtfully.

“A cannon? Intriguing. But if that’s anything like a trebuchet, it’s not as much of a problem.”

She’s so...*calm* about this. I just stare at Magnolia, a woman unafraid of guns or cannons. She stares back.

“Well, a year is more than enough time for me to locate any signs of manufacturing. But just to be sure—name one of the components of this ‘gunpowder’ for me, if you would.”

Instantly, I shut my mouth. Magnolia just sighs loudly.

“Don’t be obstinate. I said *one* component. I am hardly inclined to go around searching for how to make the stuff if I could just torture it out of you. And since I am not going to...”

She’s right. I have to trust her. Reluctantly, I open my mouth.

“Sulfur.”

Both of Magnolia’s eyebrows shoot upwards. She exchanges a glance I can’t read with Ressa.

“Ah. *That’s* troubling.”

“What? Why’s that?”

The woman just stares at me and raises an eyebrow again.

“If I told you, could you even help? No? Then I won’t.”

That—she knows something, doesn’t she? Someone’s already making a move on sulfur! Does that mean the secret’s out? Can she stop it? My head’s racing, but the cooler part of me doesn’t panic. Magnolia’s right. I can’t do anything. I have to...trust her.

Trust that she’s telling the truth. So, reluctantly, I put that out of my mind and stare at Magnolia. Everything seems, well, good so far.

That’s worrying. I can’t have been called here just to talk about weapons and how useless they might be right now. No—there’s something else.

“Is that it? If you don’t want weapons, then why *am* I here?”

Magnolia pauses as she reaches for the tea pot. Ressa, gently pulling said pot *out* of Magnolia’s reach, meets her mistress’s gaze.

“Was that a foolish question, do you think, Ressa?”

“It seems reasonable to me. She does not know you.”

“Ah, well, we’ll let it slide.”

Magnolia turns back to me and gives me a beaming smile.

“Of course you’re not here just to talk about weapons, my dear idiotic Ryoka. But I thought it would be best to set your mind at ease first.”

“I’m going to ignore that. Once.”

“How intelligent. Now, would you like to ask the obvious question? I promise I won’t order Ressa to hit you.”

“Fine. Why *am* I here? What do you want to know?”

Magnolia smiles at me. Her eyes sparkle, and she sits up, the very image of a dignified [Lady]. Her reply is quick, decisive, insane.

“Ice cream.”

“What?”

There must have been something in the pot. That’s why Ressa’s engaged in a silent tug-of-war with Magnolia. Or else she just doesn’t want her boss’s teeth to fall out. But Magnolia abandons the tea pot to look seriously at me.

“I just want ice cream. And cake. We have some types of cake—not nearly as good as yours, mind you, but something similar to what I have heard described. But the other children tell me it is possible to make an ice cream *cake*. I would like to try that, and frosting. And whipped cream. And cotton candy.”

Oh my god. She’s got a *sweet tooth*. I mean, I knew that already. But she brought me—here—over four hundred miles—

I put my head in my hands. This can’t be happening. But it is. And when I think about it...

I look up sharply.

“No.”

“No?”

Magnolia looks hurt, and offended.

“Whyever not? This is hardly a secret worth keeping, Ryoka Griffin. Compared to a gun, what is a mint, chocolate chip, cookies and cream, caramel ice cream sundae with sprinkles?”

I want to vomit just listening to her. But I read past her trite words to the deeper meaning below them.

“It’s not just ice cream and desserts you want, is it? It might start that way, but after you ask for recipes, you’ll ask me about other technologies

from my world. Little inventions and innovations that can help everyone.”

Lady Magnolia pauses. She looks at me, sighs, and then looks at her maid.

“Ah. She figured it out.”

“She is not a complete idiot, milady.”

I stare at the two of them, filled with grim certainty all of a sudden. Now I get it. Their tones are light, but I know they’re watching me. Lady Magnolia still looks genuinely disappointed, though.

“You are correct, intelligent Miss Ryoka Griffin. In truth, I was going to have you explain to one of my [Chefs] how to make all kinds of treats before I got to the rest. I have a larder stocked with countless ingredients if you’d want to...? Ah, it’s too late. How tragic.”

She sighs dramatically.

“At least the other girls know how to make cake. But no one can tell me how cotton candy is made! But you are quite right. That would only be the start of what I ask of you.”

First comes cotton candy. Then comes steam engines, or crop rotation. Or the periodic table. Plastic, sporks, bicycles...

None of this is bad stuff. In fact, I think if I could introduce this kind of technology to the world I would. But not through her. Not through this woman.

There’s more than one kind of power. And giving Magnolia Reinhart a monopoly on every invention from the medieval ages to the modern one? It might even be worse than teaching her how to make a gun.

“You want me to help you become even richer than you already are, is that it?”

“Rich enough to buy a Walled City. That would be a nice start.”

Magnolia smiles at me, like a proud parent watching over a child. I want to kick her in the face, but Ressa’s watching me.

“You figured it out—well done! Guns are an unstable bit of technology, but it is hard to take over the world with—what did the others call it? Parfait? It sounds delicious, and I’m sure it will earn me tens of thousands of gold coins when one of them finally figures out how it is made.”

It’s sick. It’s stupid. It doesn’t sound right. But the scariest and most powerful person in this world right now isn’t a general with an army of tanks. It’s a business magnate who wants to orchestrate the biggest monopoly and buyout the world’s ever seen.

Money. If Magnolia Reinhart is known for one thing, it's money. If she had unlimited funds—she could buy out every mercenary on the continent, fund unlimited armies. Money is power, and even if the power of money isn't unlimited, it's scary.

Now you know, Ryoka. You know her twisted, wicked, sugar-based schemes. Now how are you going to get out of this?

"I wonder. How indeed?"

It's like she can read my mind. I stare at Magnolia, but her face is innocent. Did she really...?

No, she can sense my intentions. She can probably sense that I want to leave and extrapolated from there. But...that's still really scary.

"And the worst part is, I am clearly an ally of sorts, aren't I, Ryoka Griffin? I can stop the world from using guns. But as for the rest..."

I still can't trust her. That's my conclusion. I stare at Magnolia Reinhart and feel my heart begin to beat faster. It's like a drum in my chest, thunder in my veins, a knock at the door—

"Again?"

Magnolia turns towards the door, frowning in genuine irritation. I stare at the door too, and see the same unfortunate maid poke her head in. She looks pale—and she goes ghostly when she sees Magnolia's frown.

"I am so sorry—"

"Get to the point."

Ressa snaps and the maid curtsies as if she were ducking a bullet.

"The mage—he's demanding to see you, Lady Reinhart. He won't take no for an answer—"

"Tell Nemor that if he does not sit still and wait for me to summon him, I will throw him out of my estate."

Lady Magnolia's voice is impatient, and she clearly means every word. The maid gulps, but takes one look at Ressa and clearly decides that arguing with a mage would be a lot more fun.

The door closes and Magnolia turns back to me with a sigh.

"I believe dear Nemor will regret that when we meet. In fact, I am sure of it. I don't even know why he's calling on me today."

"Why don't you talk to him? I was just leaving..."

I stand up, making a show of dusting myself off. Lady Magnolia smiles at me.

"Oh no. *Sit.*"

It's too fast for me. My legs fold up and I sit. I glare at the woman, but she just chuckles.

"You can't get away that easily, Ryoka. And even if my Skill doesn't work—there *are* truth spells and even potions, you know."

This is bad. I eye Ressa, and remember the potions and bags on my belt. But those are good against enemies who can't move faster than I can see. And I'm sitting in the mansion itself.

No—I knew fighting was a bad idea. I take a deep breath.

"You cannot keep me here."

"Oh? That's a bold statement to make."

Don't I know it. I meet Magnolia Reinhart's gaze squarely. She studies me—not with arrogance and overconfidence like some helpful movie villain, but calculatingly.

"Hm. You have a plan, don't you? Well, go on. I like to be entertained."

"I won't help you."

"Even if all I want are inventions that will help everyone?"

"Even then. Because that would mean placing too much power in just your hands. Too much wealth."

"And this is a bad thing because?"

"Absolute power corrupts absolutely. No one person should be entrusted with all that."

"My power is hardly absolute."

Lady Magnolia looks amused, but then her gaze sharpened. Her eyes prick at my skin like knives.

"But I take your point. You don't trust me. But tell me, Ryoka Griffin. How will you *stop* me from doing what I please? I already have many travellers from your world who know of wondrous inventions. I only need you to fill in the gaps, and then my [Blacksmiths], [Carpenters], [Mages], and [Alchemists] will do the rest. I even know [Engineers]."

All the things she needs to reverse-engineer any number of gadgets. I swallow hard.

"But you need me. What if I'm not here?"

"Oh? And how will you stop me?"

Legit question. My eyes travel to the window. I have three ways to get out of here. Three bargaining chips. The first—

Is hovering outside, making faces at me. I grin.

"I've got friends who bow to no [Lord] or [Lady] or even [King]."

I point to the window. Magnolia and Ressa turn—and see Ivolethe. The tiny faerie waves at me, and taps her ears. She can hear us? Even better.

“Um.”

A voice interrupts me. I stare at Magnolia. She’s looking at the window and me with a blank expression.

“What is it exactly that I should be staring at?”

I open my mouth...and nearly swallow my tongue.

She can’t see Frost Faeries. Suddenly I feel like an idiot. But then Ressa’s eyes narrow, and she tucks a hand into her skirt.

“Magnolia, step back.”

“What?”

To her credit Magnolia vacates the couch even as she says that. She stands behind Ressa, suddenly wary as the maid stares at the window.

“What is it, Ressa? Something invisible?”

“No.”

Ressa stares hard at a spot just to the left of Ivolethe. The faerie is just grinning, grinning at me. She’s got one hand raised and she points to Magnolia and Ressa. Then she draws a finger across her throat. Where’d she learn that? But for once I’m in full agreement. I nod slightly and she laughs outside the glass.

“There is a Winter Sprite outside the window.”

“A Frost Faerie? Really?”

Magnolia squints at the window and then gasps. Instantly she looks at me, eyes narrowed.

“Now isn’t *that* interesting?”

I feel uneasy. She—shouldn’t be this calm. Ressa’s certainly treating Ivolethe like a threat. And for good reason.

My tiny friend has been flying around the glass, making faces only I can see. But after I gave her my plea for help, she acts. She flies up to the window around head height, and puts her hand on the glass pane.

Instantly, the window becomes frosty. Magnolia gasps—not really in alarm—and Ressa immediately tenses. But what can she do against a force of nature?

The frost from the window grows deeper, and suddenly ice begins to form, thickening on the pane. Slowly, it begins to spread into the room, and I feel the temperature drop like a stone. More ice begins to spread from the

window. Is Ivolethe trying to trap Ressa and Magnolia? What about me? If the window breaks—could I jump for it?

I'm tense, my hand on the smoke bag Octavia made for me. I'm watching Ressa, ready to move. And she's looking from the window to me. It'll all be settled in a moment—

“That’s quite enough.”

Magnolia’s voice makes all of us pause in place. Even Ivolethe blinks as Magnolia steps out from behind Ressa. The taller woman moves to block her, but Magnolia just pushes her aside.

“I will handle this, Ressa.”

She steps up to the frozen window, where I can see Ivolethe reflected through the clear ice. Magnolia stares a bit past Ivolethe, but she shows not a tiny shred of fear in front of the faerie. But—she’s just a [Lady], right? And Ivolethe isn’t inside—

I tell myself Magnolia’s powerless. But I can’t help but feel uneasy. And there’s a twinge of uncertainty even on the faerie’s immortal face. She stares at Magnolia. Magnolia just sighs.

“How on earth did Ryoka meet a creature like you? Well, I’d love to chat, but I’m told on very good authority that you lot are troublemakers. I can’t have that right now. Kindly go away or I’ll have to make you leave.”

Ivolethe stares at Lady Magnolia incredulously. Possibly no one has ever talked to a Frost Faerie that way before—at least, not for long. She thinks for a second, then makes an unmistakable gesture and conjures a snowball.

Ressa seems to *blink* in front of Magnolia as the snowball smacks into the glass in front of the woman. But Magnolia doesn’t even flinch. She sighs, and then she raises her voice. Gone is the normal tone, her light and friendly air. Her eyes are filled with that same intensity, and her tone booms and cracks like distant thunder.

“I am Lady Magnolia. This mansion and the land around are mine. You are not welcome here. *Begone.*”

I feel her last word in my *bones*. The effect on Ivolethe is immediate. She flies *screaming* out of Magnolia’s courtyard as if she’s been set on fire. I see her faint azure form flitting high, high into the sky until it disappears. Magnolia watches until Ivolethe’s gone and then turns back to me.

“Well, that’s that. Did you have any other allies, or was that it?”

Holy shit.

I—

Was that—?

Uh oh.

Ressa's staring at me now too, and the look in her eyes says that she's going to beat me into a pulp the first chance she gets. The ice Ivolethe conjured isn't going away; rather, it's beginning to melt off the walls.

"I do hope you had another plan. I'll admit this one is novel, but it's rather short-sighted, don't you think?"

Magnolia smiles at me, eyes still filled with that horrible authority. Part of me wants to give in or run just looking at her.

But the rest is resolute. This woman can't have her way.

Trump card. Trump card. I take a breath and pray like hell what Erin told me was on a level. I open up with my second trump card to play.

"You can't keep me here. I have something important to do."

"Oh? Something important? Running deliveries? Delivering a birthday message and a ring? Helping Erin? Do tell."

Oh, that smile. I smile back at Magnolia and notice hers wanes a tiny bit.

"Not Erin or adventurers. I have to convince the Antinium not to go to war."

For a second—oh, for a lovely, wonderful second, I have the pleasure of watching Magnolia's smile vanish. Her eyes widen, and she stares at me.

The one upside to verbally sparring with someone who can sense your intentions? They know when you're not lying.

The glorious moment of seeing Magnolia Reinhart uncertain lasts for a heartbeat. Then she looks over my shoulder.

"Ressa."

I don't even see the woman. I don't even get a chance to react. Her hand grabs mine and suddenly I'm in an arm-lock that's an inch of force away from breaking my arm. I can *feel* my tendons tearing.

"Don't break her arm yet, Ressa. But be wary."

I barely hear Magnolia over the pain. Arm lock. I'm in—I know how to counter. But if I do—

Gah! I don't move. After a second that feels like forever I see Magnolia step back from me. I know she's staring at me.

"Please explain that sentence, Ryoka Griffin."

Arm is agony. Pain is—all consuming. But I force the words out, nearly choking on them.

“The Antinium are not your enemy.”

Pause. The pressure on my arm isn’t reduced. Can I hear my bones creaking?

“Go on.”

Maybe it’s the pain, but I let my mouth do the talking.

“What do you mean go on? I said, they’re not your enemy? Don’t you understand that you id—*argh!*”

Ressa twists my arm up a bit more. I shout in pain, but I’m afraid to move. Magnolia sighs.

“Ressa, she’s not lying. Let her go.”

“Are you sure?”

“I am. She’s not lying. And if she’s telling the truth—”

The pressure releases all at once. I stumble forwards, feeling at my arm. The pain isn’t gone. It’s—

I’ve got a potion at my belt. I wrench it out and unstopper it with one hand. Some goes on my shirt, the floor—the rest hits my arm. Instantly, the throbbing, burning pain ceases. I turn and stare at Ressa.

And...a dagger. She has one in her right hand. It looks very sharp. And magical. I’m assuming the green tint to the edge of the blade is magic. Maybe it’s poison. Poison magic?

“Put the blade away, Ressa.”

Magnolia sighs as she stares at both me and Ressa. Slowly, very slowly, the maid tucks the blade up the sleeve of her uniform. She stares at me. I watch her.

“I’m sitting down.”

Magnolia’s voice makes both of us start. She steps over to the couch and sits down in it. Then she swivels, and puts her feet up on the edge of the couch as if she’s on a therapist’s couch. She stares at me.

“Well? Explain.”

I don’t need to be told twice. Rubbing at my arm, I take a seat. Ressa silently walks behind Magnolia. Both women stare at me, waiting for me to speak.

“The Antinium aren’t your enemies. Not necessarily, at any rate.”

I look at them. Nothing. Well, they’re good listeners when things are serious. I take a deep breath.

“The shortest way to explain this is that the Antinium’s true enemy isn’t you. They fought two wars here, but to them, this is only a—a skirmish. A lull before the larger war. They don’t want this continent, I think. They’re just getting ready for their real enemy to emerge.”

“And what’s that?”

“A god.”

How easy it is to say. How...easy. And it slips off the tongue as if it means nothing. Perhaps it does to most people in this world. I can’t even begin to understand what it means myself. But Magnolia Reinhart hears this and the look on her face changes again. This time, I think I see fear.

“Impossible.”

Magnolia says that word flatly. Her eyes are locked on mine.

“The gods are dead.”

I shake my head.

“Tell that to the Antinium. Tell that to the Queens. They fled Rhir because they were fighting something they believed was a god. Or do you think the Antinium would run from any other opponent?”

Pause. Stare. Ressa’s looking at me now, not with hostility, but something approaching genuine worry. She looks at her mistress. Magnolia closes her eyes for seven seconds. What she thinks in that time I don’t know. But when she opens her eyes—

“How do you know? This must have come from a credible source. And I don’t believe the Queen would talk to you. If this came from a Worker—”

“No Worker.”

I shake my head.

“Klbkch. He’s a Prognugator in the Antinium Hive based in Liscor—”

“Klbkch the Slayer.”

The word escapes Magnolia’s lips. She sits up on the couch and stares at Ressa. Something unspoken passes between the two, and then they look back at me. Magnolia’s voice is serious when she speaks next.

“You have my full and undivided attention, Ryoka Griffin. For the moment I’ll believe everything you say. Do not waste this chance.”

“So you believe me?”

“Oh yes. At least, I believe you are telling the truth. And if it was Klbkch the Slayer who told you this...”

Magnolia’s voice trails off. Ressa looks at her, worried.

“Does this change the plans?”

The other woman nods, shortly. She even laughs, but not with any pleasure.

“Of course. It changes...everything. It changes the entire world.”

She looks back at me, about to ask another question. Then someone knocks. The door opens.

“Lady Reinhart? The [Mage]—”

This time Magnolia doesn’t wait. She grabs the tea pot and *hurls* it at the door.

“*Get out!*”

I see the tea pot shatter, but before the pieces even hit the floor, the maid has fled. Calmly, as if nothing happened, Magnolia turns back to me.

“You were saying Klbkch the Slayer told you this?”

“You know him?”

Magnolia’s face is grim as she nods.

“I know him. I have seen him on the battlefield. Perhaps before that, but we met for one brief moment during the Second Antinium War.”

“The Second Antinium War?”

I only read about the first one. Damn. The second one was mentioned, but I think I lost the book that talked about it. Magnolia frowns at me, and then looks at her maid.

“Ressa, fetch the book for me.”

It’s clear which one she means. Ressa walks out of the room, and Magnolia turns back to me.

“Tell me the rest.”

I do, as concisely as I can in the time it takes Ressa to return. Magnolia keeps interrupting me, but when her maid is standing by her side with a slim book in her hands, she sighs and accepts it. She looks at the book before handing it to me.

“What’s this?”

“The history of the Antinium, all the information known about their culture, and a history of both the first and second Antinium Wars.”

Magnolia taps the cover as I hold it in my hands. I read the title. *The Antinium: A Brief History by Krsysl Wordsmith*. The name is familiar to me.

“Wasn’t he the one who wrote about the First Antinium War?”

“He was.”

Lady Magnolia nods as I tuck the book into the bag of holding at my side. She notes it, but makes no comment. I guess the Antinium really do

trump all other concerns.

“I funded his research and the book. I would advise you to read it, the history of the Second Antinium War in particular, especially if you are going to be working with Klbkch.”

Huh. I look up at Magnolia, surprised.

“So you’re going to let me go?”

“Didn’t I say I hated stupid questions?”

The woman scowls at me, but weakly. Her heart’s not in it any longer. Ressa looks at her and Magnolia nods wearily.

“That’s right, Miss Ryoka who knows too much. You win. If there is a slight chance—however slight!—that there could be a way to avoid a war with the Antinium, I would take it. And the knowledge that there is dissent within the Hives—from a Prognugator no less? Invaluable. Even more invaluable is the knowledge of what the Antinium fear. If there is a god—”

She breaks off and shakes her head. Then she fixes me with a gaze like diamonds.

“You have changed everything I seek to do, Ryoka. Do you know that?”

I meet her gaze.

“I do.”

“From this moment on, you and I must be allies. We must be, because I must pursue peace with the Antinium and find out more of what they know, and because you will not live with me as your enemy. I promise you that.”

Magnolia’s eyes are hard as she captures mine. I can’t help it. I swallow, but that’s all. I don’t look away.

“So, what should we do? As allies? I trust you won’t be keeping me here or extorting information against my will?”

Lady Magnolia smiles.

“On the contrary. If we’re allies you should be giving that to me for free. But we can...negotiate that later. For now, you are officially my guest. That means I feed you, in case you were wondering. I’ll even allow that Winter Sprite back on my estate, if you can find her. I would like to talk to her as well, if that is possible.”

Wow. Suddenly, everything’s changed. I shift in my seat. What should I explore first? Does this mean what I think it does? If I have an ally—

The wall explodes. Mortar and stone blast outwards in a single thunderous impact that sends the couches, tables, and me flying. I windmill

through the air, trying to curl and reduce the impact. No good. I hit something hard and then I think the world stops for a second.

I don't know. All I do know is that when the pain and shock stop long enough for thought to shakily resume, I'm pulling myself up. Something in my thigh. A fragment of stone. Deep. I don't feel anything broken—but everything hurts.

“What...?”

I look around. The room is in ruins. The wall's gone—and a huge stretch of corridor gapes at me. But what I see in the center of the room is more important.

Lady Magnolia and Ressa are standing in the center of the room. Untouched. Even their clothes aren't ruffled. It's like...the explosion didn't hit them. I see a radiant nimbus around both of them.

Shield spell?

But someone else is standing there too. A man in robes. He's...tall. I feel like throwing up. But magic shines around him, so strong I can see it. He blew up the wall.

And he's talking. I hear his voice dimly over the ringing in my ears.

“Magnolia Reinhart. The Circle of Thorns seeks your life.”

He must be the Great Mage Nemor. I try to get up and collapse. My leg

Magnolia Reinhart stares at the mage. She looks around at the destruction. Her eyes linger on me for a second, and then she stares back at the mage.

“Well.”

It's just one word. She's not afraid—rather, her eyes are full of cold fury. But aside from Ressa she is alone. And even as I watch I see a shadow move. An [Assassin] steps out of the darkness as if he's a ghost. And more—they flit towards her. Surrounding...more...

I can't breathe. I have to warn her. Ressa's standing with her back to Magnolia, tense. But—there's too many. And yet Magnolia is not afraid. She looks at the mage. Looks down at him.

“The Circle of Thorns? You have my full attention.”

3.14

I think I have a concussion. The world is spinning and I want to puke. Then again, maybe that's just how being thrown across a room by an explosion always feels.

I don't know. I haven't had much experience with that up until now. And I hope it never happens again.

"Ah."

I try to move and just sort of flop over. I'm partially covered with bits of fallen masonry, so no one in the room notices me twitching. Which is good in this case, because it's sort of *tense* right now.

Lady Magnolia and Ressa are standing in what used to be her sitting room, surrounded by assassins. Excuse me. [Assassins] and one assassin who happens to be a mage. He's dressed up in colorful yellow robes with green slashes down the sides. He glows with magic. But the [Assassins]—

Shadows, some of them. Others just look like blurs and I'm sure there are more I can't see. Only a few even look remotely humanoid. Best guess? They're high level and they've got magical items as well.

And they're all armed. I'm sure of that. They're backing up the mage, but they haven't attacked yet. The idiot—the Great Mage Nemor I think is his name—is talking. He's actually gloating, like a movie villain.

"—Never thought I'd live to see the day when I would finally humble the arrogant Reinharts once and for all."

"I don't think you'll live to see that day either. But one can always hope, I suppose."

That's Magnolia for you. Surrounded by death and she's got more attitude than anyone I've ever met. It makes me almost like her.

I look groggily at the scene. Lots of badness over there. That's my general assessment. I could...use a potion? Smokescreen bag? Flour bomb?

All of my instincts tell me that trying anything will get me instantly killed. So instead of doing anything stupid—like usual—I just lie on the ground and watch things play out*.

*Yeah, not my most heroic moment. But in my defense, I did just get tossed into a wall. It hurt.

“—Arrogance will do you little in the end.”

Oh, they’re still talking? Don’t assassins generally make less noise? But this Nemor guy seems to want to get the final word in. He juts out his chin—he’s got a small goatee which looks immaculately oiled and groomed. It suits his narrow, pointed face. He clearly wants to look like a great mage, but aside from the blowing stuff up part, he doesn’t really look that impressive.

Granted, that last bit does a lot for him, but even so. Words are not his strong point.

“Grovel, Reinhart. If you do, I may make your end quick.”

“Oh please.”

Magnolia rolls her eyes heavenwards.

“Do us all a favor and *shut up*, Nemor. You always were insufferable even when you were just casting ward spells for me. If you’re not going to tell me what this Circle of Thorns wants, kindly die without speaking, would you?”

The mage’s face turns red. He opens his mouth—but he never gets a chance to retort. One of the shadows standing in the ruined hallways moves. The [Assassin] charges at Lady Magnolia *fast*—faster than I could ever move. He’s got a dagger in his hand as he lunges at Magnolia’s chest.

But the blade never touches her. I see a blur, and then Ressa is in the way. She blocks the strike with her own unarmored chest. I nearly shout as I expect to see her body pierced by the thrust.

But that doesn’t happen. Instead, I see the shimmering aura around her body—the magical shield that protected both her and Lady Magnolia—brighten. I hear a man scream, and the [Assassin] suddenly stumbles back, clutching a stump of a hand already spurting blood.

What was that? His hand *vanished* as it approached Ressa’s body! And now Ressa moves—the unfortunate [Assassin] chokes as her fingers go *into* his neck. She pulls her hand back and he folds over. I feel my stomach heave as I see what happened. Part of his face is just gone, vaporized by whatever magical shield is on Ressa.

The other [Assassins] move even as the first one dies. Two lunge at Ressa, but she *blurs* and they retreat as I hear metal clashing. One tosses the remains of a blade to the ground—all but the handle is vaporized. The others attack from a safer distance. Darts, throwing stars, knives—they hurl

them at both Ressa and Magnolia. All the projectiles vanish before they touch either woman's body.

Ressa flicks her hand and I see dark blurs speed at the [Assassins]. At least one hits, but even the blurred shape I see stagger doesn't fall. They blink backwards as Ressa immediately steps back to Magnolia, guarding her back.

Standoff again. The [Assassins] pause and then wait, as if nothing happened. Nemor stares at them, and his face only now goes red as his mind catches up to what just happened.

"You fools! Hold until I command it! I must bypass her protection spells first!"

He shouts at the others around him, not even seeming bothered by the magical disintegration field. Magnolia sighs calmly, not even ruffled by the sudden burst of violence.

"A proper mage would have done that first rather than sending that poor man to his death. But then again, a proper [Assassin] wouldn't have attacked so recklessly to begin with."

She points at one of the shadows, and they shift, as if they're afraid to be directly addressed by her.

"You have some rather showy magical items and Skills, but none of you are master [Assassins]. Believe me, I can tell the difference. Who sent you to die here?"

No response. I just see the shadows and blurred figures flitting around Magnolia, as if suddenly unsure. She scowls at them, impatient and not afraid.

"Well? *Answer me.*"

"We were—"

The words come out of one of the shadows unwillingly. I hear a female voice, and then she *gurgles* as one of her fellows strikes her in the throat. She chokes and falls back, but says no more.

Magnolia scowls again. She points at Nemor, who's gone red again with rage.

"Who ordered you to work with this fool? I was under the impression your Guild didn't collaborate with amateurs."

"Fool!? For the last time, you insult me. Magnolia—"

"*Be silent, Nemor.*"

I see the man recoil as if struck. Nemor's hands go up to his throat and his face goes red, then purple. Calmly, Magnolia turns back to the [Assassins].

"Was it your Guildmaster? Or someone else? Tell me who sent you."

This time they're ready. I see a few of the [Assassins] shift, but none of them speak. But the idiot—Great Mage, rather—sneers and answers instead. His face is regaining some of its color. Looks like he also shook off the charm spell. Damn. Is it really that easy?

"There are more factions that seek your life than you know, Reinhart."

She pauses, and looks at him.

"Hm. So that means the Guild *didn't* officially sanction this. Well, thank you for telling me, Nemor."

Never before have I seen a man look so angry and worried at the same time. Nemor's face turns amazingly maroon with rage. He hisses at Magnolia.

"I will see you suffer before you die."

"And I see there's little more to be learned here. Well then, shall we be about the business of the day?"

Magnolia turns to the [Assassins]. Immediately, I see them ready their weapons. But she doesn't reach for a weapon. Rather, Magnolia folds her hands together. She's not wearing gloves and her dress probably isn't concealing a weapon. I just see a few rings on her bare hands. She looks around the room, as if searching for a spot to properly fight.

I tense as her eyes spot me lying on the ground, but Magnolia doesn't even acknowledge my presence. Her gaze sweeps over me as if I'm not there. Magnolia shakes her head slightly as she turns and speaks casually to Nemor and the [Assassins].

"Not here, I think. There are too many valuable antiques that would need replacing. If you would follow me...?"

She doesn't move, but her hand turns one of the rings on her fingers. I hear a curse—Nemor raises his hands and several [Assassins] have already thrown more weapons—but it's too late. Magnolia and Ressa both vanish from sight in an instant.

"Teleportation!?"

Nemor exclaims in surprise. I see several shadows streak down the corridor in an instant, but the mage's shout draws some of them back.

"No—wait."

He points at the spot where Magnolia and Ressa have gone, thinking out loud.

“There’s no spell circle. And no one can teleport long distances so quickly. This fast—they must be headed to a prearranged destination. Spread out and find them!”

Way to state the obvious, genius. I get the impression that Nemor’s not actually in charge of these [Assassins], and that’s clearly for good reason. The other shadows just streak down the corridors—two run past me to the exposed opening. I hear another voice, a man’s, from one of the shadows.

“Outside.”

I don’t know how, but all of the [Assassin]’s silhouettes immediately return and make a beeline for the exposed opening. They disappear into the night air, leaping or vanishing over the edge. Nemor runs after them, cursing, and I see him jump off the broken ledge as well. His body glows, and he falls much more slowly than gravity should allow.

What’s happening? Is it safe? I don’t know. Part of me wants to stay here, but—I have to see what’s going on. Slowly, painfully, I crawl out of my lovely blanket of broken wall fragments.

Don’t stand. Just crawl. I worm my way over to the void where the wall used to be, exposed by Nemor’s spell. And then I see her again.

Lady Magnolia.

She’s standing in the center of her courtyard, bold as you please. She didn’t even teleport more than a hundred feet! Ressa is by her side, and she’s—fighting?

It’s all a blur of motion in the darkness below. I see countless flickers of movement, and see flashes of light. The [Assassins] are going after Magnolia and Ressa with everything they have. Ressa is a blur around Magnolia, deflecting missiles, clashing with the [Assassins]—but there are too many. The only thing keeping both her and Magnolia alive is the bright aura around them that’s shielding them from harm.

But it’s growing weaker. I can see the glow fading, especially now that it’s the only contrast against the darkness outside. Each time a throwing star strikes Ressa’s shield it dims, and the [Assassins] are too smart to go hand-to-hand with Ressa. She catches one of them and kills him by striking his face—when she pulls her hand back half his head is gone. But the others just jump away and keep hurling weapons at her.

I stare down at the courtyard full of blurring shapes in shock. There's a damn *war* going on down there! What do I do? I can't just jump in—I doubt I'd even last a minute. And my potions and alchemist tricks aren't going to work here.

But if I don't, Magnolia will die. Right?

She has to be doing something. I see Magnolia's hands moving in the courtyard, although I can't tell if she's holding anything amidst the fast movement. But she seems to be working on something—she doesn't even look up as an [Assassin] closes on her and Ressa forces the killer back just in time.

What is she doing? Now she looks up. At what? A cloud?

The cloud? That wandering cloud from her garden? It's right overhead. I stare at it. It's roughly in the same place as when it rained at me. Magnolia looks up at it. But then her head turns.

Someone is striding across the courtyard, glowing with golden and sapphire light. Nemor's entire body is wreathed in some kind of fantastic magical shield—it looks like water, filled with gold dust. He doesn't even seem to notice as Ressa hurls two throwing stars at him—they sink into the barrier around him and disappear, as if they've fallen into a sea.

He points at Magnolia as he strides towards her. The [Assassins] charge with him, but Magnolia's face is cool. She looks back up at the storm cloud and seems to sigh. I see something bright spark amidst the darkness of the cloud overhead.

“Reinhart! You will—”

Lightning strikes Nemor right in the chest. I see the world light up and go blind. I jerk backwards as I hear the *thwoom* of the sound and feel the impact a moment later. The sound is deafening, and the image of the coruscating bolt of electricity is burned into my retinas.

“Holy—”

The rest of my exclamation is drowned out by more flashes, and more thunder. I raise my head and peer over the edge to see lightning bolts shooting out of the rain cloud. And not just one or two.

A crackling storm of lightning blasts the earth around Magnolia and Ressa. They stand perfectly still as the cloud over their head turns from an innocent rain cloud into a flashing avatar of destruction. I see shapes fleeing from Magnolia in every direction, but the lightning is *alive*. It flashes down

and curves towards the retreating [Assassins], blasting them to bits as they try to run.

In seconds, it's over. All that remains are smouldering corpses, or pieces of them. I stare down at the courtyard as my vision slowly clears, spotting broken stone, scorched spots—and death.

They're all dead. All, but two.

Nemor slowly stands back up, his magical shield crackling as the last burst of electricity earths itself around him. One of the [Assassins] who took cover behind the mage gets up as well. The shrouded figure—denuded now of its shadowy concealment—looks at Magnolia and Ressa. Without a word, it flees back towards the mansion.

“Coward! Come back!”

The mage shouts after the retreating [Assassin], but the figure pays no heed. I can't blame them, either. After what I just saw, I'd run or surrender rather than fight the sky.

But Nemor stands in front of Magnolia, no longer gloating but not fleeing either. Magic – a kaleidoscope of colors – swirls around his hands as he points at her.

“Your defenses might have killed the fodder sent to assist me. But I did not come here to fail, Reinhart!”

“Oh really? And who else do you have to die with you? More [Assassins]? I do believe I've cooked all of them, but I'll happily do it to a few dozen more.”

I can hear Lady Magnolia's voice, light and poised, from my position on the second floor. Nemor's voice is filled with rage, but also confidence.

“Not just [Assassins], fool! Behold! Even your own tools are turned against you!”

He turns and points. I see movement in the darkness. The glint of light off of metal. Out of the darkness, ten Golems, the massive suits of plate armor armed with two-handed greatswords emerge. They take up positions behind Nemor as he laughs wildly.

“See how all is turned against you? The Circle of Thorns has roots in every place, even in your own home!”

“I see. Lightning wouldn't work so well against them, would it?”

Magnolia sighs as she stares down at the Golems. I see Ressa take a blade out of her skirt, but Magnolia stops her with a hand on one arm.

“You know, those were a present for my sixteenth birthday. I’ll have to get rid of them now; once compromised there’s no trusting them. Couldn’t you have found some other target instead?”

“You seem to think you’ll still survive.”

Nemor sneers up at Magnolia. He raises a hand, and something bright flashes into being. I see a...blue fireball appear in the mage’s hands. It’s blue around the edges, and in the center I see a white-hot flame swirling.

“Your precious shield spell is nearly exhausted. Will it withstand my magic, and the Golems for more than a few seconds?”

“It doesn’t have to. Once you’re dead the Golems will stop attacking as well. It’s very simple, Nemor.”

Magnolia lightly retorts. I see her raise her hands. She’s putting something on her index finger. I can’t see clearly what it is from this far away. Another ring?

Nemor doesn’t give Magnolia a chance to use it. He hurls the blue fireball, and the explosion engulfs the two women. I feel the blast from here—the air blows my hair and makes me cover my eyes. When I dare look again, I see Magnolia and Ressa, standing in the same spot.

What happened? Their shield must have absorbed the spell again. But it’s gone now, and Nemor has two more fireballs in each hand. He’s laughing.

“Well? Will you grovel now?”

“I still don’t see why I should.”

Magnolia’s tone cuts Nemor off. He snarls—and she continues, speaking over him.

“A powerful, if idiotic mage strong enough to bypass my wards, a group of [Assassins] to take down my mage, subverted control spells for my Golems—they even made sure to choose someone I trusted enough to let into my estate. This Circle really did manage to subvert all my outer defenses. For a first attempt, it was quite well done.”

“There won’t be a second time!”

Nemor roars in fury. He hurls another fireball at Magnolia, but this time Ressa moves. She draws something out of her skirt—a mirror?—and holds it up. The fireball is sucked into it. Nemor shouts.

“That cheap trick won’t work more than once!”

He points and the Golems lumber forward. But Ressa runs at them, hurling something onto the ground. Vines sprout up—a tripvine bag?

Something like that, but these vines are huge, easily engulfing even the massive Golems and walling off the rest.

“You can’t protect yourself forever!”

The mage’s hands glow and he burns half the vines away in an instant with blue flame. He actually *melts* one of the Golems with his spell, but he doesn’t seem to care. He tries to catch Ressa, but she dodges backwards to Magnolia’s side.

“Your [Maid] can’t save you, Reinhart! She can’t breach my magics!”

“She doesn’t have to. Nemor, you are a fool.”

Magnolia’s finger glints with crimson light as she points at the mage. A thin line of light shoots from the ring she wears and spears the mage through the chest. My breath catches—but the light doesn’t seem to do anything. And yet—it goes straight through Nemor’s shield and out the back of his body. What is it?

Lady Magnolia’s voice is light and calm. I hear her in the sudden silence.

“If you had begged—no, even if you had, it is far too late. This is the price you pay for overconfidence, Nemor. And betrayal.”

The Great Mage Nemor pauses. For a second I think he didn’t even see the line of red light, so thin is it. But then he spots it and goes still.

“Oh.”

He stares down at the thin red line pulsing in his chest. When he looks up at Lady Magnolia all his confidence is gone.

“Please. Have m—”

“No.”

That’s the only word I hear. What I see is the burning line suddenly expanding. The thin line becomes a beam of burning air—a pillar—Nemor’s form is engulfed in a column of fire and then it *flashes*—

This time the impact knocks me backwards. I hear more masonry falling around me and instinctively curl up into a ball. Miraculously, Magnolia’s mansion doesn’t fall to bits around me.

My head is spinning. I’m still blind. I slowly uncurl, and gasp, remembering to breathe.

What? What was—

Was that a railgun? No—it was similar, but whatever that burning line was expanded. Some kind of explosion.

I raise my head up, although I really want to keep it down. What I see when I dare look back in the courtyard is simple: I see burning ground, the dark night, fallen bodies.

And Lady Magnolia, standing in the center of the courtyard, still pointing, her finger aimed straight at her enemy's chest.

And where Nemor once stood? Nothing. A crater of black, smoking ash is all that remains. He is dead, and the Golems stand lifeless, some still tangled in the vines.

It's over.

For a while, I just lie there, staring down at the courtyard. Lady Magnolia and Ressa look like they're talking. My eyes are drawn to them—and then the devastation.

Gods. How many people just died down there? A bunch of [Assassins]—even if they weren't 'masters', they had to be high-level. And that Nemor—what level was he?

I don't know. I can't even guess. I just witnessed a conflict that I'm far too inexperienced to even guess the magnitude of. It leaves me shaking.

Eventually, though, I stand up. I have to do—something. I wander back towards where the door used to be. I stare down the empty hallway, and then, finally, hear the other sounds.

Sound. It's such an odd thing. As I lay watching the battle, I could only hear the clash of metal, Nemor's voice, and the roar and boom of the magical spells. But now I hear other sounds.

Distant shouting. Crying. The voices of people. Who?

[Maids]. [Manservants]. The staff of the house, that's who. As I slowly walk back into the non-destroyed parts of Magnolia's estate, I suddenly remember them. And I see them, rushing about, tending to the wounded.

The wounded? Yes—the [Assassins] and Nemor didn't just attack Magnolia. They struck the servants in her home first. I pass by multiple still bodies, stabbed or burnt practically to ash. But the few casualties of those unfortunate enough to get in the way are nothing compared to the wounded.

Several [Maids] are desperately trying to keep a man lying on the ground alive. He's stabbed in the stomach—multiple times by the looks of it. But there are three shapes on the ground, all dressed in black clothing.

Assassins? They're all dead. The servants must have fought them off. The maids look up at me and I—

Stab wound. They took the blade out, which is bad. The bleeding is severe. I grab the nearest cloth I can find—a dead [Maid]’s dress—and press it against the man’s stomach as hard as I can. I ignore his cries and get the other [Maids] to help.

I keep the dressing there, trying to stop blood from flowing, keep the man alive. Somehow, he holds on long enough for one of the [Maids] to dash back with a potion. She pours it on the wound and it heals instantly. The man sits up, gasping.

He lives.

I stand up and go. My hands are covered with blood, but I pay no attention. I feel like a dreamer, walking through Magnolia’s grand home, now filled with death and destruction.

I give aid one more time, helping bind a tourniquet until a potion can arrive, and then I find the last [Assassin]. The one who ran.

He lies on the ground, a hole in his chest, black clothing still smoking from where something burned away part of his leg. Two people are standing over him, a [Butler] and a [Maid].

I blink at Reynold. He and the maid both hold weapons in their hands. A shortsword and buckler in his hands, and a glowing wand in the [Maid]’s. They stare at me, first wary, then relaxing.

“Miss Ryoka. Are you unharmed?”

“Mm?”

I stare down at the [Assassin]. Filled by some unshakeable curiosity, I pull back his hood. I see not a man’s face as I’d assumed from his build, but a Gnoll’s. Dead.

“Miss Ryoka?”

I look back up at Reynold. He looks concerned for me. He moves his hand and I flinch, but he touches my head gently. He shows me...blood. On his fingertips.

“You’re hurt. I have a healing potion—please, hold still.”

I let him pour a bit on my temple. The pounding in my head stops. Huh. I didn’t even realize my head was throbbing until this moment. And I feel—a bit more steady.

I stare back down at the [Assassin]. Then I look back at Reynold. He looks grim, but he’s dealing with the situation better than I am at the moment. I hesitate, and then point at the dead Gnoll, grinning stupidly.

“Does this happen often as well?”

He just stares at me.

“Not in my lifetime. But I have heard stories of attempts made on one of the Five Families’ before.”

“Oh? And what comes next, then? What will Magnolia do?”

He looks at me as if it were obvious.

“She will go to war.”

The problem with winning, Lady Magnolia reflected, was that the winner inevitably had to clean up. Oh, of course some fools might choose to let the dead lie where they were, but that was only an option on the battlefield, and in her experience, most battles took place outside of battlefields.

She stood in what remained of her lovely courtyard, sighing and staring at the dead bodies as Ressa barked orders by her side. Magnolia knew better than to interrupt—Ressa’s control over her staff didn’t have any room for her, so while Ressa coordinated her people, Magnolia chattered. She often did that in times of stress; and every other time as well. She didn’t like silence.

“Not a shred of warning. Not a *hint*. What good are all my informants and spies if they can’t warn me of an impending attack?”

“I believe that is why it is known as a ‘sneak’ attack.”

Her [Head Maid] paused in the act of ordering a group of servants to race through the mansion to distribute healing potions. Naturally, Magnolia’s estate had many potions and artifacts for emergencies, but it was one thing to be prepared and another to be ready for an actual attack. Magnolia’s heart ached as reports came in of the servants who had gotten in the way of the assassins and Nemor during the attack.

Something would have to be done. They would have to train the staff, not just those experienced in combat—especially if this was a forecast of things to come.

“Even so, the fact that not one person reported anything unusual happening is telling, isn’t it, Ressa? Our spies are compromised.”

Ressa nodded briefly. That much was as obvious to both women as the moon.

“Some will have been caught off-guard. Others were bribed or threatened. More were traitors to begin with. It will take a great deal of work discovering which is which.”

“However, if this *is* the Circle of Thorns and not some pretenders...this is very serious, Ressa.”

“I know.”

More people rushed up to the two women. Magnolia listened with one ear while she thought quietly. She stopped one maid, though.

“What was that about an [Assassin]? Was the last one found?”

Ressa nodded.

“Reynold and Sacra caught the last one as he was trying to flee. He is dead.”

“Dead?”

Magnolia’s tone was irate. She glared at Ressa, ignoring the [Maid] who fled from her presence.

“Couldn’t you have captured that one alive? I want at least one witness to interrogate. What good are dead bodies to me? I don’t know any [Necromancers]—at least, none that I trust!”

She knew she was being petty, but she was in a bad mood. Ressa clicked her tongue disapprovingly as she responded to her mistress.

“That would have been an unnecessary risk. These killers had unknown Skills and magical items. Killing the escaping one quickly was the correct decision for Reynold and Sacra to make and I stand by their decision.”

“You would.”

Magnolia grumbled, but she let the matter drop. She knew it would have probably been pointless anyways—[Assassins] were notorious for dying to protect their client’s secrets. She paused as she heard a voice in her head.

“Magnolia!”

“Oh, Ressa. I hear Teriarch. I’ll have to talk with him.”

Ressa nodded, and stepped away as Magnolia began to speak into the air.

“I’m here, Teriarch.”

The old Dragon’s voice was urgent in her mind.

“Magnolia! I received your signal. Are you—?”

“Fine. There was an attack. Assassins and a mage came to kill me.”

“Assassins? Are you sure you’re safe?”

“I’m fine, old fool.”

Magnolia's tone was acerbic, but she relented a bit when she heard the genuine concern in Teriarch's 'voice'. She could almost picture the Dragon anxiously fanning his wings.

"If you think they might be around, I could be there in minutes. A spell or—I could fly!"

"You? Fly all the way here?"

The woman snorted, amused by the idea.

"If you want to come I'd welcome you. But Ressa tells me the place is secure, and she would know. I have my own [Mages] and artifacts who will be able to safeguard me, you know that."

There was a pause as Teriarch considered Magnolia's reply.

"If Ressa says so...tell me what happened!"

Briefly, Magnolia related the events to Teriarch.

"Will you come or not? I could use you here."

She held her breath, but not much. Teriarch's reply was everything she expected.

"Well...if you're safe, then I hardly need to go out. Other mages can take care of the rest—but you should get rid of the Golems."

"I know. But it's such a waste. I got those for my birthday, you know."

"Nevertheless. If one mage can seize control of them, they cannot be trusted. You need a better Golem anyways—how often have I told you not to rely on these shoddy animated suits of armor?"

"Oh? And what would you propose?"

Magnolia snapped at the empty air. Teriarch's voice was arch as he replied.

"Any superior construct would do. A Gemstone Golem would have far more utility as you well know. Ivory Golems are too susceptible to interference via death magic of course, but if you would just buy a Magestone Golem—or even a Truestone Golem—"

"Not even you have a Truestone Construct lying around. And besides, I'm fairly certain those were outlawed in several nations."

"Hmf. Wistram has one."

"And she is not for sale. Believe me, I've asked and she is definite on that subject. Teriarch, I have work to do. If you aren't coming—"

"Very well. I will contact you later. But if you need help—"

Magnolia's voice was soft.

"I know. I will ask. But there's only so much you can do in that cave."

She heard no reply. Instead, she sensed the magical connection break. Magnolia turned back to Ressa, and found the woman was waiting for her.

“All done?”

“Things are stable for now.”

“Good. Then find me Ryoka Griffin. I only saw the girl sensibly had her head down after Nemor blasted through the wall. Do you know where she is? Is she hurt?”

Ressa shook her head.

“She is alive and mostly unharmed. At the moment she is helping tend to the wounded.”

“Really?”

“Really.”

Magnolia paused.

“Good. There may be some hope for her after all. Take me to her.”

The two began to walk into the mansion. Magnolia sighed as she looked at the injured, but she kept talking to Ressa as they walked.

“It’s begun, Ressa. It’s war, you know that, don’t you?”

“Against the Circle of Thorns?”

“Wherever and whoever they may be. I have an idea of where to start, but—”

“The same problem as before?”

“If my great grandmother’s diary is right, it will be a nightmare. Still, we can’t let them do this again. I think you know what we have to do.”

Ressa waited. Magnolia made a face as she forced herself to say the words out loud.

“I’ll need to gather my flight of attendants. My allies, anyone who can be trusted—do you know where all my attendants are right now?”

“Right where you left them. The Reinhart estate in First Landing.”

“Damn. I hate that place.”

“When should we leave?”

“Tonight. Have Reynold get the coach ready. We can be back soon, but we have to move *now*.”

“And Ryoka?”

“Well, for the moment...”

An hour ago I was talking about the fate of the world with Magnolia. Now I'm standing in the rubble of her mansion, helping pour healing potions on the wounded.

In fairness, there's not that much rubble and no longer as many wounded. The wards on the Reinhart estate are sturdy, and Nemor only destroyed one room. But the air still feels tense, electric with fear and anxiety.

And grief. I stand up from tending to what used to be one man's leg and turn to find Lady Magnolia and Ressa. They stare down at the [Manservant] as he tries to get up and fails.

"Stay there."

Ressa's voice is calm and imperious. But she kneels and inspects the man's stump of a leg with gentle hands. The wound is healed, but his leg is gone. Burnt away. He shudders, but doesn't cry out like he was doing earlier. He only looks up at Ressa and Lady Magnolia.

"I regret—I'm afraid I won't be able to wait tables any longer, Miss Ressa."

"Don't worry about that. Just rest."

Ressa lies the man back and more servants come to lift him in a stretcher. I watch them take the man away, and see Ressa's gaze follow him.

She does care about the other servants. She might act like a general from hell ordering them about, but she cares.

And Magnolia—

I glance at the other woman. Lady Magnolia Reinhart is standing in the corridor, coolly surveying the devastation. People rush around her, and occasionally she'll direct someone, but for the most part she just lets Ressa work.

She's not down there tending to people herself. But she is radiating calm authority like a lighthouse. That's a type of leadership, and I can see it reassuring the people around her. They look to her.

"Ryoka Griffin."

Now her eyes find me, and I shudder. I can't take comfort in her presence. Not after what I saw. I nod to her to cover my unease.

"I saw what happened."

"Hm. Well, I am relieved to see you weren't hurt. I was almost afraid you'd jump into the fight."

No fear of that. I stare at the one-legged man as he disappears down the corridor.

“What will happen to him?”

“Who?”

“The man...with the missing leg. What will happen to him after this?”

Magnolia blinks at me, surprised by my question.

“What do you mean?”

“Will he lose his job? He sounded like he was a waiter.”

“Of course he won’t lose his job! I will find a new one for him that he can fulfill with one leg. That is all that will happen. Why, did you think I would fire him?”

I can only shrug. Magnolia scowls. She seems genuinely annoyed with me.

“No one injured in my employ will ever face losing their job. I do not abandon my people.”

“Oh. Good.”

I turn my back and stare at the people hurrying around me. I can tell Magnolia is eying me balefully from behind.

“I trust you understand this complicates matters.”

“I kind of got that when all the [Assassins] appeared. What was the mage talking about? Who are the Circle of Thorns?”

Magnolia pretends she didn’t hear my question.

“Sadly, I have suddenly become far too busy to hound you on the matter of inventions from your world. I will do so at a later date, but for now I believe I will have to let you go.”

I turn and meet her eyes.

“Do you think I’m an idiot? I know this isn’t over.”

She rolls hers.

“Of course it isn’t. But by all means, attend to your own business. We are allies, so I shall make sure you meet with the best experts in Invrisil. Tomorrow.”

“Experts? What experts?”

Another eye roll. Magnolia points at my side, at the bag of holding I’m carrying and snaps.

“*Magical* experts, idiot! I know your adventurer friends uncovered some relics. Well, I will have some meet with you. And then, when I am done attending to this—you and I will talk again.”

“Great.”

Magnolia raises an eyebrow, but that’s all I have to say on the matter. She sighs, loudly.

“You are an obnoxious child sometimes, you know that? You remind me of Ressa when she was young.”

Ahead of her, Ressa turns and glares at Magnolia. I do the same. Magnolia waves her hand at the two of us.

“You will sleep here tonight. Ressa will find you a room.”

And so she does. I stay awake long enough to see the mansion slowly settle back into some kind of normalcy—and then I go to the large, extravagantly adorned room that has been allotted to me. I lie on the bed, but I’m still far too awake to sleep.

I can still see the lightning, still see the line of fire engulf Nemor. I don’t know what it means, and I’m almost afraid to find out. But one thing I do know.

The sky is already beginning to brighten. I try to sleep, willing myself to rest for however long I can. I think I’ll need the energy. I’m not done here. Not by far.

Invisil, the City of Adventurers, awaits.

Day 45

A lot can happen in a day. I mean, that’s a fairly obvious statement, but I find myself surprised, sometimes, at how much can happen.

Forty-five days. That’s how long I’ve been in this world. But although I had a lot of amazing, unforgettable experiences in these forty-five days, the last few have seen the most happen.

Especially three days ago. Three days ago I survived my first avalanche. I coordinated a rescue effort; I touched a dead person, and saved a life. More than one for both counts, if I’m honest.

But I choose to remember the living. And I have to keep moving forwards rather than dwell on the past; a lot more rests on my shoulders, now.

It’s a bit...ironic. A few days ago Durene and I were effectively outcasts living on the edge of Riverfarm, barely tolerated for who we were. Well,

Durene was barely tolerated; I was more popular. But we were both shunned for our relationship.

And now? Now our little cottage is our hideaway from the rest of the world. At least if we stay there we can sleep in peace.

In three days, I went from being a blind man with an unhealthy obsession with half-Trolls in the eyes of the village to being an [Emperor]. Of course, I was always an [Emperor], but they didn't know that.

They do now. True, I didn't exactly advertise the fact, but everyone heard me when I first took control of the village. And word spreads fast.

How would you react to having an Emperor in your village? I'd imagine normally there would be a lot of questions and maybe even suspicion or hostility.

But in this case? There's none. The villagers saw me running from spot to spot, finding people trapped in the snow. That earns you a lot of trust, not to mention gratitude. I am an [Emperor], and the villagers treat me as such.

Which brings me on to the downside of my current living situation: I'm an [Emperor]. And Riverfarm is now technically under my dominion.

Which, defacto, makes me their ruler. Which also makes me responsible for them. And makes them subservient to me.

And boy, do they take that role seriously.

"Are they still outside, Durene?"

I hear her rustle as she sits up and looks at the window.

"I think Gamel's still out there."

"Still?"

Or should I say, 'already'? I frown as I sit up in bed next to Durene. It's barely past dawn, and there's someone out there?

"Did he camp out here?"

"I think so. He's got a fire and everything."

"We should have invited him in. Not that there's space, but..."

I mutter to myself as I put on pants and a shirt and coat. I try to stay low; one of the downsides to being blind is that you can't really tell where windows are or if doors are open. It means I'm somewhat paranoid about flashing someone by mistake.

"Why is he even out there? I told them I'd be back as soon as I woke up today."

"I think they wanted to have someone here in case you needed anything."

Durene answers cautiously as she readies some tea and rekindles the fire. She knows how I feel about suddenly being the ruler of Riverfarm, but I can tell from her voice that she's pleased.

And can I blame her? She used to be the village laborer, the barely-tolerated half-monster girl. And now she's the consort of an [Emperor], or my personal servant, or whatever. The point is that even though our relationship isn't a secret, no one's throwing rocks at Durene, and everyone treats her with almost as much deference as they treat me.

Part of that might also be her class. Durene is a Level 6 [Paladin] now. She gained the levels from helping save people and working to help the village. True, she didn't slay monsters, but her doing good deeds fits with the idea of a [Paladin] in modern culture. And for her efforts, she gained not one, but two Skills.

[Weapon Proficiency: Shield] and [Graceful Step]. Now, the first Skill makes sense to me. It sounds like a classic feat out of any fantasy roleplaying game, but [Graceful Step]? Apparently, it allows Durene to move, well, gracefully. If I put it bluntly, she no longer sounds like an earthquake when she moves around her cottage, and she can even sneak up on me now!

It's quite incredible to me, but it's also odd. I mean, why would moving silently, or rather, gracefully, be that important to a [Paladin]? Is it because the class is taking from the original idea of a paladin being a member of Charlemagne's court and being considered dignified characters? Or is it more broadly taken from the fact that paladins are supposed to be champions of justice, respected characters in the eyes of the many?

Perhaps there's another set of guidelines I don't know about entirely. All I do know is that Durene—

Squark.

I wince and hear Durene's surprised exclamation.

"Oh good. Frostwing's awake."

Indeed, the noisy eaglet has awoken, and upon finding both Durene and I are awake, is stridently, nay, angrily *demanding* we feed her breakfast. I scowl as I find the bowl of half-frozen food by the kitchen counter and shove it at the bird.

"Eat, you ungrateful fowl. Stop complaining—I haven't even had breakfast yet!"

Happily, Frostwing does just that. She's gotten even bigger than she was three days ago, and now she can peck at the food herself. I can even feel a few feathers coming in, although I've been too preoccupied with the village to attend to her as much as I'd like.

Speaking of which—

As Durene puts some butter in the pan and I delight at hearing it sizzle, I open the door and walk out to Gamel. I know the young man—he's been following me and Durene around since the day of the avalanche. And I can even 'see' him in my mind—he's camped right at the boundary of where Durene's cottage ends.

"Emperor Laken, sir!"

I hear his excited voice as I crunch through the snow. I make a face and stop before I'm too close to him.

"I told you, Mister Laken is fine."

I'd prefer to do away with even that, to be honest. But the villagers insist on calling me something. And that's way better than 'Emperor'.

"I'm sorry, Mister Laken."

He sounds *chastened*. I sigh.

"Never mind that. Durene and I were about to have breakfast. Can I invite you in?"

"I couldn't do that!"

He sounds horrified. I sigh again, but I knew Gamel would probably say that.

"You're sure?"

"Yes sir. I've got some porridge and even some smoked bacon right here, sir. A feast!"

"Well, in that case we'll be out soon. If you're cold, the door's open."

"I won't be cold. I will be waiting, sir!"

I shake my head to myself as I walk back to the cottage. How did it come to this?

I brighten up a bit when I push open the door and smell meat cooking. Durene's poking at the pan, and I can tell there are some thick slabs of ham waiting to be eaten.

"Smells good."

"It does, doesn't it?"

Durene sounds just as excited as I am as she flips the dripping slices onto a plate. She and I eat at a table—me ignoring Frostwing's chirps as she

tries to get me to feed her.

“You’re disgusting, you know that?”

“*Me?*”

“Not you, silly. Frostwing. Didn’t you just eat the entire bowl?”

“I dunno Laken, she looks hungry. She’s getting bigger—what if we gave her some?”

“Maybe later. There’s such a thing as overfeeding her, Durene.”

“Oh, right.”

“...You can feed her that one bit.”

“Okay!”

I smile to myself as Frostwing shrieks in delight and then begs for more. Who knew a bird could beg? But then my smile falters a bit as I bite into my own bit of fried ham. Yes, it’s delicious. But the mere fact that Durene and I are feasting on ham for breakfast is a concern.

We’re eating meat. And that might be normal in my world, but in Durene’s, or at least, in her village, that’s a luxury. And it’s happening because all the animals in Riverfarm are dead.

They were all buried in the avalanche, and unlike the people, we didn’t get to them in time. Chickens, pigs, cows—even if you ignore the people that died, this was a disaster in its own right. These animals are what Riverfarm depends on for food and coin, and they were all killed at once.

The one small mercy was that at least their bodies were frozen. It means that the villagers and Durene and I can eat the animals one by one and stretch out our food stocks that way. But still. This would cripple any village and make it that much harder to survive the winter in the best of times.

And after the avalanche, Riverfarm is certainly not going through the best of times. That’s why despite our big and delicious meal, Durene and I are out of the cottage in the next fifteen minutes, and we walk with Gamel trailing in our wake to Riverfarm in good time.

“Mister Laken!”

“Emperor Laken!”

“Emperor!”

“Sire!”

Countless voices greet me as I walk into the village. I smile and wave, and greet people by name. I’m used to the attention by now, at least enough so that I don’t get slowed down and get to the village center in good time.

When I'm there, I immediately cast around the village with my [Emperor] senses.

Let's see. What's changed since yesterday? Some new houses are excavated—good. Nothing's collapsed today, which is a relief. The dead animals—

—Are still frozen in the ground. But one of them looks...gnawed at? I frown.

"Mister Prost?"

With my senses I can tell the man jumps as I address him directly among the crowd. People still can't quite believe I can sense things without seeing. But he hurries forwards as I call him.

"Yes, Mister Laken?"

"One of the dead cows—the one buried just past the barn—looks like it's been partially eaten. Have animals found the body?"

"I don't know. I'll have someone check at once!"

Prost's voice is filled with consternation and I hear him hurry off. In minutes he's back with news.

"Animals did eat at the body, sir! Looks like foxes or something similar. They ate a good bit."

"That's not good."

I sigh as I hear people around me mutter. Well, I suspected this would happen.

"Looks like wildlife is returning to the area after the avalanche. We'll need to make sure they don't get at any more of the dead animals before we can properly smoke them, salt them, or preserve them some other way."

"That will be hard, sir."

Prost sounds worried. I nod, but try to look for a better angle. There has to be something...

"What if we set traps for the foragers? We could catch a few animals—maybe more food for the pot?"

"That could work!"

The man brightens up and I hear voices sounding approving around me. Jeez. As if that was some brilliant idea. Any one of them could have come up with it—they'd probably be able to execute it far better than I could since they actually know how all of this works. But they let me do the thinking and deciding, because I am an [Emperor] after all, and don't I know best?

This is how my day goes now. I coordinate with Prost about getting people to set traps up as Durene goes to help dig. She's been doing it every day—we've nearly gotten all of the houses excavated, but there's still tons of snow around the village that could be cleared out. And the fields—

"At the very least, we should focus on finding a place to store the dead animals. The barn perhaps. If we could close the doors and put the frozen bodies in the snow there, that might keep a lot of hungry animals at bay."

"We can do that. Just give the word, Mister Laken."

"I'm just worried larger predators will smell the dead bodies and come searching."

"Aye, that's true. The Emperor has a point. What if a bear scents out the carcasses?"

I hear a murmur of worry.

We'll have to have eyes on the barn, then. But we can't just let the bodies rot and keeping them buried is just asking for trouble. Let's get to it.

Prost takes command of a few villagers, and I choose more people who either volunteer or who I know have good Skills for the job. No one complains. Everyone's so full of this—this can-do attitude it almost makes my heart hurt.

Here they are, days after an avalanche that killed their family and friends, and they're putting their lives back together. Without a word of complaint. Helping one another, sharing all they have. All they needed was a little nudge to do it.

"But it isn't good enough."

I mutter the words quietly as I sit in Prost's house, repurposed to act as a central hub I can work in.

"What's that, sir?"

I shake my head at Gamel as he leans forwards to pay closer attention. It's nothing.

Liar. I know what the problem is, and I know I have to address it soon. Today. The villagers are working hard, I know that. They've excavated their village, repaired damage, worked together, buried the dead. They've performed a small miracle, but—

"But we don't have enough food to last the winter. Nor are we ready for a monster attack."

That's the situation I lay out in front of Prost and the other older villagers later that day. I hear them talking amongst themselves, but they go

quiet when I continue.

“We’ve got stores of food of course—plenty, in fact. And the harsh truth of it is that we’re benefited by having fewer mouths to feed. But—even so. We lost all the animals, and a number of cellars where the snow and ice smashed everything to bits. And there are other villages that were hit too—what if relatives come? People seeking aid, who weren’t as fortunate as us? What if there are more mouths to feed? And while we’re struggling to make ends meet, monsters could attack us at any time.”

I’ve never encountered a monster, but Durene and the others have told me stories, and they’re horrific. Monsters, especially smart ones like Goblins, love to attack when people are at their weakest. I’m sure Riverfarm is a lovely target for them, and the other villagers know I’m right.

“What should we do then, Mister Laken? Do you have a plan?”

That’s Prost’s voice again. He seems to speak for a lot of the villagers. I nod at him, trying to project confidence so he won’t be worried. Odd. A few days ago he was trying to tell me what to do. Now—

“I do. If we don’t have enough food here, and we need help, we might as well just buy it.”

“Buy it? You mean—from a city?”

Consternation fills the room. I wait for them to quiet, and then ask for opinions. Again, Prost is first up to bat.

“Pardon me, Mister Laken, but I’m afraid our village doesn’t have the coin to buy enough food—let alone hire adventurers to guard us. We never did. We could buy enough food for a few weeks maybe, or hire a few bronze-rank adventurers for the same amount of time if we pool our coin, but...”

He trails off helplessly. The other villagers mutter their agreement. It’s so—interesting. None of them want to tell me I’m wrong, even when they are telling me just that. It’s like they want to be proven wrong, to know I’ve always got something up my sleeve.

That’s unhealthy. I need to get them to stop thinking like that. Even if... they’re right in this case.

I clear my throat.

“Money will not be an issue, ladies and gentlemen. I happen to have quite enough coin to pay for whatever Riverfarm needs.”

“You do?”

I nod at Mister Prost.

“Remember the gold coin I traded you, Mister Prost? I have hundreds more like it.”

Is it risky telling a bunch of desperate villagers I’m rich? Maybe. And some would say that’s especially true since I’m blind. But I have a good read on these people. They’re honest, hardworking, loyal—even if they are a bit racist. And they look up to me.

My faith in them is not misplaced. If anything, I underestimate their spirit. After the shocked exclamations die down, one of the other villagers, a woman named Teriane, speaks up.

“Mister Laken, we can’t hardly have you paying for all of us! We’d never be able to repay you!”

The others mutter sadly in agreement. I just shake my head.

“Nonsense. No one needs to pay me back anything. I’m your [Emperor], so it’s only natural that I’d take care of my citizens.”

Also, I got the money practically for free. But when the villagers hear this, they’re moved to tears. Literally, in some cases. I feel bad—but I feel worse when they begin to cheer.

“Emperor Laken!”

“Long live Emperor Laken!”

“Emperor!”

Oh god. This is too much for me. Eventually I get them all to sit down and shut up, and I keep going with my plan.

“Okay, money isn’t an issue, but what *is* important is getting to a proper place to spend all of what I have. To that end...I’m going to Invril.”

“*What?*”

“It’s the only way!”

I talk over their exclamations. I explain as best I can.

“I’ll take Durene—and Frostwing too, I suppose. The three of us can move quickly, and go to the Adventurer’s Guild and marketplace to buy all we need.”

“But sir—you can’t! It’s too dangerous for you and—and especially Durene!”

Prost is the first to speak up. I can tell he’s agitated, and I understand why.

Durene. She’s always wanted to go to a city, and always been too scared of what treatment she might receive. But this—

“Durene is the only person who can guide me properly. I trust her, and she’s strong.”

“Then why not let one of us go instead?”

“Do you really think you’d be safe, Mister Prost? Even if I sent ten people—what if you were attacked by bandits? Or if someone tried to mug you for the gold?”

They can’t reply to that. I nod seriously.

“I’ve been thinking this over. Durene might stand out, but she’s stronger than any thug, and I...I’m an [Emperor]. We’d stand more of a chance, and besides, who would try robbing a blind man and a half-Troll?”

Well, more people would try to rob me than Durene. But the villagers still don’t like the idea.

“What will happen when you’re gone, though? Emperor, sir, we need you!”

“You don’t need me.”

I scowl as I override their objections.

“No, be quiet! You don’t need me. You did perfectly well when I wasn’t here, and I’ll only be gone a few days at the most. And when I return, I’ll have everything we need.”

“But—”

I can hear part of their fear unspoken in their voices. It’s not just the dangers they worry about. It’s that I might abandon them. I mean, it’s not as if I didn’t think of it. What’s stopping me and Durene from just leaving Riverfarm to their fate?

My duty as an [Emperor], that’s what. And if not that, my soul.

“Mister Prost.”

I walk up to the man, and take him by the arm. He starts at my touch, but I look at him. My eyes are closed obviously, but this is as close as I can get to what it would be like if I could see.

“Mister Prost. I *will* come back. Riverfarm is my home, now. This is my empire. I will return. You have my word as an [Emperor] on it.”

I don’t know what Prost sees in my closed eyelids, but whatever I say, it works. In a moment he changes from arguing against me to arguing for me.

“Trust in Emperor Laken you lot! No—quiet Melpin! You don’t know what you’re talking about. If Emperor Laken say he’ll do it—he’ll do it!”

And that settles that. Oh, of course I had to reassure people and tell the others what was going to happen, but once I got the ball rolling, it couldn’t

be stopped.

Not that there weren't a few alterations, mind. In the end it was decided that we'd take a wagon. Durene would be able to pull me, Frostwing, and the gold and some travel supplies along. I objected of course, but Durene was the one who argued against me the most here.

"I can pull you all, Laken! Honest!"

Against my better judgment, I agreed to it, especially, as it turned out, because we'd be getting company. Gamel was chosen to accompany us—as a sort of helper to Durene and someone who could talk to guards and whatnot.

It made sense, and I couldn't get the villagers to budge, so I let it all pass. That's how we found ourselves getting ready long into the night, and I drew up some plans for the villagers to follow while we were gone.

Day 46

"The cart is loaded?"

"Yes sir!"

"Frostwing's secure in her nest?"

I hear her shrill cry and nod.

"Durene? Are you sure about this?"

"Positive! Look, I can pull this so easily!"

Durene demonstrates and I wobbled and nearly lose my balance standing on the wagon.

"Oh! Sorry Laken!"

"Nevermind that. Okay, it's time!"

I turn and wave to the villagers. They cheer and call out my name. Durene pulls the wagon, Gamel shouts and hollers back at his sweetheart, and we set out down the snow-covered road. The villagers worked all night to clear it so we can travel on and the ride isn't nearly as bumpy as I thought it would be.

I sit back down in the wagon and feel the comfy, warm blankets around me. The villagers really spared no expense giving me the luxury accommodations.

"Durene, just let me know when you get tired. If you can't pull us all the way, I'm more than happy to get out and walk."

"I'm fine, Laken! I could even pull Gamel!"

“That’s fine Durene. I like walking. I could—help pull if you need it.”

“No, I got it!”

We move onwards. I feel the fresh morning air in my face and sigh.

“This is so weird.”

“Isn’t it exciting?”

Durene’s voice is filled with delight and apprehension in equal measures. I can just tell she’s twisting in place as she walks to stare up at me.

“I’m so nervous, Laken! We’re going to a city! Not just a city, *the city!* The City of Adventurers!”

“I’ve never been there myself. Is it amazing?”

“Yes!”

Both Durene and Gamel chorus at the same time. I grin.

“But neither of you have been there before, have you?”

Practically none of the villagers have. Invril is a huge city, and the people of Riverfarm trade with the local town rather than go all the way there. But the city is the dream of all young folk.

Including me, I guess.

“Laken?”

“Yes, Durene?”

I can hear the worry in her voice as she pauses before speaking.

“Do you really think it’ll be alright? I mean...for me?”

I take a while before I reply. That was my worry too. But...

“It’ll be okay.”

“You’re sure?”

“There might be some people who just look at you and judge you from first glance, but if there are, I’ll deal with them. I am an [Emperor], after all. And you are my lovely subject.”

“That makes me relieved. I mean, I’m just so nervous! We have a fortune in the wagon! What if someone finds out?”

Durene says it again, but I can tell she’s feeling better. I tease her as we go up a small slope that apparently leads out of the village.

“How will anyone find out? Unless you shout it to them, that is.”

“I’m just saying! There could be bandits, or monsters—”

“You’ll just have to defend me, then.”

“*Me!*?”

“Of course you! You’re my [Paladin], after all, aren’t you?”

“I guess...”

“Oh come now. Don’t worry, Durene! What’s the worst that could go wrong?”

Frostwing squawks in my ear, and Durene giggles. I sit back as Gamel starts talking about being an adventurer and maybe even going to Wistram, and Durene excitedly asks him what magic he’d study, and turn my face up to the sky.

I can’t tell whether it’s cloudy or clear skies above me. And maybe that’s a good thing, because I can always imagine that there’s a blue, clear sky overhead and the sun is shining bright. I’ve never seen blue, but I imagine it’s the color of adventure, of a new day.

Of hope.

Of course, I’ve always thought green was a rather hopeful color as well. But who ever heard of a green sky? Ah well, it’s all the same to me.

The wagon rumbles on as I, Laken Godart, [Emperor], prepare to go to Invril, the City of Adventurers to save my poor village from starvation and monsters. I lie back, breath in. And at last—

I begin to explore this vast world.

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3.15

Erin Solstice carefully flipped a fish on the frying pan she was holding over the fire. She watched the one golden-brown side of the fish turn over and land neatly on the oily surface of the pan. Instantly, the uncooked side began to sizzle.

“Mm. Fish.”

That was all she said for a while. There was nothing else that needed to be said. She just inhaled and smelled the fillet as it cooked. When it was done, she had a plate ready. She slid the still-juicy, crispy-golden fillet off the pan and looked at it.

It was a bit of perfection, at least for her. Back home, she’d never made anything nearly as good as this, not even close. The old Erin wouldn’t even have known where to begin, let alone mix up the batter that gave the fish such a nice, spicy taste.

And indeed, this fillet could have probably won her an award if she’d entered it in a local cooking competition. Erin knew it certainly could have gotten her a job at a local restaurant.

And it was all because she had a Skill. Erin stared at the fillet as it gently steamed on her pan. It really was a wonderful bit of food she’d created.

But.

Erin turned with the plate in her hands, and then dumped the fillet she’d just fried to perfection onto a cutting board. She diced the fillet in a few seconds with a cooking knife, and then shoved the remains into another pot.

This pot contained soup. To be more accurate, it contained blue soup, thick as molasses, with bits of green and some kind of yellow substance that looked like mutated pond scum bubbling to the surface. Erin mixed in what had been the wonderful fillet and sighed.

“It looks awful. But I *think* it will work.”

Compared to the fillet the soup looked about as appetizing as dirt. Undeterred, Erin poured some into a wooden bowl. Carefully, she took it out of the small kitchen and into the shop. There she stopped and called out.

“Octavia? I’ve got more soup for you to try!”

No one replied to her voice. Erin frowned and looked around. Octavia's small shop, Stitchworks, was fairly big, but it felt cramped because of all the shelves full of potions and alchemy reagents stockpiled everywhere. Thus, she quickly found the dark-skinned girl with braids hiding under one of the tables.

"There you are! Come out and try the soup!"

"I'm not going to. You can't make me!"

Octavia refused to budge, even when Erin put down the bowl of soup and poked her a few times in the side.

"Come on out. I promise it's not going to be that bad this time."

"I don't want to. *You* eat it!"

Erin put her hands on her hips and sighed.

"You're the one with all the Skills that prevent you from being poisoned or dying, remember? And I don't have a detachable stomach."

"Just because I can eat it, doesn't mean it tastes good! And I still feel the effects of what I eat! I was squatting over the toilet for hours after that last soup you made!"

"Aw, come on. You weren't there *that* long...this time will be different, I promise! I didn't add anything dangerous to the food this time."

"No! Eat it yourself if you're so confident!"

The girl hesitated, and stared at the bowl of soup on the table. It was probably safe. Her [Dangersense] wasn't going off, at any rate. But she didn't want to taste it, even so.

"Octavia..."

"No!"

"I'll pay you."

There was silence. Octavia slowly poked her head out from underneath the table.

"How much?"

"Four silver coins?"

"Hah!"

The head withdrew. Erin thought quickly.

"Fine! Two gold coins! *If* it makes you sick or does anything bad to you. Deal?"

"Deal!"

Octavia was out from underneath the table in a second. Erin sighed, but there was something gratifying about how easy it was to just pay Octavia to

do things. The Stitch Girl had a refreshingly simple way of looking at the world. If it was profitable, it was probably worth doing.

Even if the it in question involved eating another one of Erin's soups. But then, Ryoka *had* paid Octavia quite handsomely to help Erin, so in that sense, Octavia was actually earning more for just doing her job.

Then again, even Erin had to admit she'd been feeding Octavia a lot of horrible stuff over the last few days. She would have actually volunteered to eat some of it herself, but without Octavia's Skills that helped protect her against acid, burns, poisoning, and other nasty effects, the [Alchemist] would have been dead from eating some of what Erin had cooked up.

Instead, she'd just gotten horribly, sometimes violently, ill. Which explained her reluctance to sample any more of Erin's experiments. However, Octavia loved gold even more than her health, so she didn't look that put out as she stretched and looked at Erin.

"Alright. What horror am I supposed to be eating this time?"

Erin beamed as she showed Octavia the bowl. To her credit, the Stitch Girl didn't even blink at the appearance of the soup. She sniffed at it cautiously as the human girl explained.

"It's a variant of the last stew I made. This time I think it's all mixed correctly."

"Hmf."

Octavia sniffed disparagingly; her nature as an [Alchemist] made her look down on all of what she called Erin's 'abominations of cooking and magic'.

"You found a way to stop the Stonelizard scales from mixing with the lemon juice and melting?"

Erin hesitated.

"I...think so. I kept the heat low and made sure to add a lot of mint. The soup hasn't melted through the bottom of the bowl, so it probably worked."

Octavia sighed. But she obediently picked up a spoon and gingerly spooned some of the blue glop into her mouth. She chewed a bit and swallowed as Erin held her breath—then Octavia made a face.

"It's all *mushy*!"

"Eat!"

The girl did so, albeit reluctantly. Erin stared at the stitching around Octavia's neck as the Stitch Girl slowly consumed the bowl of soup. It still seemed weird to her that Octavia was actually just cloth held together by

string. Shouldn't some of the soup leak out around the stitches, no matter how tightly it was sewn? But apparently, once Octavia's cloth parts were connected, they acted like real flesh and blood.

The sound of the spoon scraping the bottom of the bowl made Erin look at Octavia sharply. The [Alchemist] sighed in relief as she put the spoon down and looked up at Erin.

"...Huh. It tasted pretty foul. Way too minty, and was that fish in there?"

Erin nodded, smiling.

"The pan frying and batter did the trick. The fish helped warm the soup without making it burn like last time."

"Smart, I guess."

Octavia looked grudgingly impressed. One of the biggest challenges Erin had had to overcome was the issue of heat. Octavia could regulate the temperature of her potions with ice and flame, but Erin had less options when it came to cooking. Just making the soup bubble in some cases could lead to dramatic—and dangerous—reactions.

"I think it might have worked."

The [Alchemist] said this after a few minutes. She prodded at her stomach. Erin felt surprised, and immediately happy.

"You're sure?"

"Pretty much. One of my Skills would have kicked in by now and I'd definitely be feeling the effects if anything harmful was in the soup. The only thing to test now is whether the effects were reproduced."

"Oh. How are you going to test it? I could hit you—"

"No, thank you. I'll use a pin instead."

So saying, Octavia went up to her counter and rummaged around below it. She came up with a small box of pins, some scissors, and quite a few spools of thread. Erin guessed that was the equivalent of a first aid kit for Octavia.

"Alright, here goes."

Octavia pulled out a rather long and sharp pin out of the box and extended her arm. Erin expected her to lightly poke at her flesh, so she was shocked when Octavia took the pin and pressed it straight into the center of her arm.

"Oh! Ow!"

"Hrgh."

It looked as bad as it must have felt. The innkeeper winced as Octavia pushed the pin into her skin with all her strength, grimacing with pain as she did. Erin held her breath—it was almost hard to watch, but she had to know if the soup had worked.

“Well, would you look at that?”

Octavia’s grimaced expression changed to one of amazement. The Stitch Girl held up the pin, and Erin felt a jolt of elation in her stomach as she saw the pin was bent.

“It worked!”

“It did.”

Erin threw up her hands and shouted in delight. Octavia just stared down at the pin, blinking as if she couldn’t believe it. Once Erin had calmed down—she couldn’t really run around waving her arms in the shop without knocking over something delicate—she and Octavia sat together and discussed Erin’s latest creation.

“It really works, doesn’t it! Your skin is tougher—although it still hurt when you poked yourself with the pin, didn’t it?”

“A bit. I was more ready for the pain than anything else.”

Octavia studied the pot of blue sludge and Erin’s scrawled notes, shaking her head.

“This is—insane. It’s definitely a magical effect like you’d get from a potion, but how are you coming up with this stuff? First the strength stew and the Corusdeer soup that warms you up—now this?”

Erin beamed as she circled the particular combination of ingredients that had worked on the grubby piece of parchment.

“I’m on a roll. And you said it couldn’t be done!”

“I was wrong, clearly. That’s my mistake. Why does everything have to be a *soup*, though?”

Erin shrugged.

“Soup is easiest. I’ve tried batters, but I need to get all the ingredients right before I can use them. Now that I know the ingredients for this soup for instance—I could probably make a stir-fry or something out of it!”

“Huh.”

Octavia fell silent, drumming her fingers on the kitchen counter. Erin stopped and stared at the other girl.

It had been nearly a full day since Ryoka had run out of the city. It had been even longer since Erin had come to Celum—nearly a full week, in

fact. And all that time she'd been splitting her time between Miss Agnes' inn, the Frenzied Hare, and Octavia's shop, Stitchworks. As a result, Erin was not only financially sound for the moment—Agnes had told her she was earning more in a week than she and her husband normally did in a month—but she'd managed to come up with some amazing new discoveries in Octavia's shop!

Erin had been trying to cook with alchemical ingredients to create foods just as amazing as the soup she'd come up with that Ryoka kept using. And she'd made progress. Amazing progress, even Octavia had agreed. It was just that...

Some of Erin's elation faded away as she stared at the soup in the pot. It had taken her nearly a hundred tries to mix this up, costing countless gold coins' worth of ingredients. That wasn't the issue, though.

Octavia didn't seem to notice Erin's feelings. She idly poked the pin into her hand as she stared at the soup.

"You know, if you want to try making the soup into an actual dish I wouldn't mind trying it again."

"Maybe later. I want to try and finish the other dishes, though."

"More?"

The Stitch Girl frowned at Erin.

"How many more times are you going to come over and take over my shop? I do need to make potions myself, you know."

Erin nodded absently.

"Yeah, but Ryoka bought out your time."

"She did, but..."

Octavia waved her hands in the air, trying to express her displeasure.

"It's been—how long? Nearly a week?"

"Something like that."

Erin helped herself to her own bowl of soup now that she knew it probably wouldn't kill her. She made a face as she tasted the horrible dish she'd made—the mint really was too powerful, but it was sour as well! She'd have to find some other way to combine all the ingredients—blend the mint into the fillet batter and keep the lemon juice out of it until the very end, or something.

But the dish *was* edible. Octavia shook her head as she stared at the small pot of soup Erin had brewed up.

“How am I supposed to deal with this? You’ve just created—what? A Thickskin potion? But you’ve used way less reagents than I usually do.”

“Mhm.”

Octavia glared at Erin, incensed by the bland response.

“Don’t you know how incredible that is? If you could do that with every potion I’ve made—just think of the savings! This is amazing! Revolutionary!”

“Yup. This really tastes bad.”

Erin made a face and Octavia made a sound of disgust.

“Well, I’ll admit that you have some skill at this. But—and I’m asking again—how many more times are you going to use my kitchen and store?”

“Ten thousand times.”

“Excuse me?”

“Ten thousand times. That’s how many times I’m going to cook. If I can, that is.”

Erin suddenly felt very tired as she turned to Octavia. The dark-skinned girl’s mouth was open in shock, but her eyes were flittering left to right in sudden calculation.

“If you did that, I’d have to at least charge you—”

“I’m not being serious! Jeez!”

The Human girl scowled at Octavia. Octavia scowled back.

“You could have fooled me! I’m just giving you a price quote. Why ten thousand times, anyways?”

Erin sighed. But she felt like explaining, so she took a seat and spoke to Octavia between spoonfuls of the horrid soup.

“Back where I come from—there’s this guy who said that the best way to get good at something was to do it ten thousand times. Or something like that.”

Wasn’t it ten thousand hours spent practicing? Erin couldn’t actually remember that well.

“Anyways, the idea is that if you want to learn how to do something well—really well, I mean, you have to practice that much. You can be as talented as you want, but in the end you still need to practice.”

“Oh. So that’s why you’re trying to make all this stuff?”

“Sort of.”

Erin nodded, stretching her neck out a bit and wincing at the *cracks*. How long had she been cooking today? Already three hours, probably.

“I have a Skill—[Advanced Cooking]. It lets me cook really well without practice. But lots of people have that Skill. I’m an [Innkeeper], but there are a lot of people with higher levels than me, I bet. They have better inns, more Skills...I want to match them, somehow. So I decided to try to learn something new—even if this is boring.”

“Boring?”

“Boring. I think making all this alchemical stuff is boring. I know you don’t—”

Octavia’s outraged glare was proof enough of her feelings. Erin just shook her head tiredly.

“—But I don’t like wasting food, and making all this complex stuff. But it’s all that I can do.”

The other girl paused before she could give Erin a tongue-lashing.

“What do you mean?”

“I’m not like Ryoka. She can run around and do cool things—she’s even got Ivolethe as a friend.”

“Who?”

Erin ignored the question. She stared at the mostly empty bowl of soup and took another bite. It tasted awful. But it *was* magic.

“I can’t be a hero. I don’t like fighting, and I’m scared of getting eaten. Or stabbed. Or stabbed and eaten. All I can do is try and make my inn better. And if I had something magical to sell to my guests—no one would be able to copy that. That would make my inn unique. That’s why I’m doing all this.”

Even if it was hard. Even if it was exhausting. This was her big chance; Erin knew that. She raised her head and saw Octavia’s face. The girl didn’t look irate like she normally did around Erin. Instead, she looked impressed.

“That’s actually quite thoughtful for you.”

“Surprising, right?”

Octavia had to grin. Her teeth flashed in her dimly lit shop. Then she looked back at the bowl in Erin’s hands and her eyes narrowed in a calculating look that made Erin groan internally.

“You know—not that I’m trying to renegotiate the deal Ryoka made with me or anything—but you *have* benefited a lot from the recipes I’ve come up with. If you’d consider selling me them, I’d cut you in on a deal. In fact, why not let me sell them to other inns and taverns? Why, you’d earn a lot more if everyone was making this stuff and not just you. I’d only ask

for a small commission on each sale—and I’m sure that the profits alone would—”

“It’s not going to work, Octavia.”

“You don’t know that! If you’d just listen to the rest of my idea—”

Erin shook her head, cutting the other girl off. She handed the recipe of the soup she’d just made to Octavia.

“Try making it yourself.”

The [Alchemist] was surprised, but she wasn’t one to turn down an opportunity to make something useful—and, Erin suspected, memorize the recipe. But although Octavia eagerly piled the ingredients into another pot and followed all of Erin’s instructions to the letter, her hands quickly slowed down as she frowned at the floating objects in the water of the pot.

“What’s happening? It—it’s not even reacting. It’s just sitting there. Like...”

“Like nothing is happening?”

Erin nodded and took the spoon from Octavia. As she began to stir, the soup began to change. Octavia’s eyes widened as she stared at the way the individual ingredients suddenly began to dissolve, mixing together.

“How are you doing that? A Skill?”

“Yup. It’s my Skill. Without it, no one else can make this stuff.”

Erin watched as the mixture slowly thickened, and continued following her instructions, although she knew how to make the soup by heart. She explained to Octavia as she reached for a glass of lemon juice she’d painstakingly squeezed earlier.

“I tried to show Agnes how to make the Corusdeer soup. She couldn’t do it, even when she copied me exactly.”

“What skill do you have? [Magical Cooking]? I know it can create magical dishes but this—this is different.”

“[Wondrous Fare]. That’s what I have.”

Erin didn’t tell Octavia how she’d gotten it, but she explained how she could make the faerie flower drink. True, alchemy ingredients weren’t the same as hallucinogenic faerie flowers, but Erin thought what she was doing still made sense. Octavia nodded, finger on her lips as she thought out loud.

“You’re probably bypassing one of the natural steps in the creation process. Perhaps you’re skipping the need for a particular reagent? There are some high-level [Alchemist] skills that can do the same. Some really

save on costs since you can practically create lesser healing potions for free by skipping on the need to mix up the proper base first—”

She broke off, shrugging.

“It doesn’t really matter. But there goes my idea of marketing this stuff and making a fortune. Only you can make it, after all.”

Erin nodded, smiling a bit. But the smile slipped.

“It’s good. I’ve finally got something only I can make, and it’s useful. It’s just—I wish it wasn’t so boring, you know?”

“*Boring.*”

“Boring. Even though I worked this hard—there’s still so much more to do, Octavia.”

Erin stretched out on her seat, feeling her tendons snapping as she tried to shake off some of the tiredness that felt like it was in her bones.

“I’m just so—tired thinking about it. I’ll get back to my inn, and then I’ll start selling this stuff. But even though I’ll probably get more customers, I still need a new helper, to build up my inn, buy some magical runes—there’s just so much to do and I can only take one small step at a time. It’s exhausting.”

“So what? ”

Octavia just looked blank. Erin glared at her.

“Don’t you wish you could be more like Ryoka? She doesn’t have to do stuff like this. She just—runs. She can do amazing stuff. I wish I could do something cool so quickly.”

Erin sighed. She didn’t like fighting or anything like that. She wasn’t as athletic as Ryoka was. She knew that. It was just that this was—well, it had been fun. But now she was just tired.

But Octavia just snorted in derision.

“Only adventurers and crazy people like Ryoka can become rich and famous quickly. Everyone else just has to work hard and gain as many levels as they can. I’m going to save every coin I can, level up and learn as many recipes as possible so I can expand my stores, make better potions, and do more business until I’m the highest-level [Alchemist] on the continent.”

She gestured around her small shop.

“I might not reach my dream for years, but it’s a lot safer than swinging a sword around. Well, safer when you’re not around, that is.”

“But that’s…”

She realized she didn't really have anything to say against that. Erin let her voice trail off unhappily.

What Octavia was saying was right. She was taking the smart option. Even if being an [Alchemist] was slightly dangerous, it was nothing like being an adventurer. It was just so boring to think of, though. But part of Erin thought that was just what being an adult was like. It was thinking about the big picture. She knew that.

So then why did hearing it all laid out like that make her so depressed? Erin didn't know, but she did come to one conclusion which made her sit up in her seat.

"I'm done cooking for the day."

Both she and Octavia brightened up when she said it. Erin was fed up with making useless soup, and Octavia was tired of eating it.

"Good! I'll just pour your horrible soup into a jar, shall I? I can probably sell it—at a markdown of course...I can give you a good split of the profits if you'd agree to oh, a vendor's fee of—"

Erin left Stitchworks and Octavia behind mid-sentence, shaking her head. She didn't mind Octavia—well, she did sometimes. But there were just some days when she needed some alone time. Or more precisely, not-Octavia time.

The sky was still gray and the streets were still snowy when Erin left the shop. She walked carefully so as not to slip as she wandered down the busy streets. Celum was always bustling, even if it was a smallish city. Erin walked past countless faces who didn't seem that different from hers—Humans, going about their daily lives who didn't give her a second glance.

That was reassuring, but also disheartening for some reason. Erin missed Liscor. She missed seeing Drakes and Gnolls, fantastic creatures going about their everyday lives. Celum was nice because it was reassuring, but it was also boring for the same reason.

Boring. That seemed to be the word of the day, didn't it? Even though Erin had come up with an amazing discovery—she still felt the word in her soul.

Bored. She wanted to do something exciting. No—not just that. She wanted to be with someone exciting. She missed Ryoka already. And not just Ryoka. She missed all of her friends.

They were back in Liscor. And Erin was far from there. She kicked miserably at a patch of snow and then looked up. What about the Horns of

Hammerad? That nice Runner guy had come by yesterday and told her Ryoka was going to see them. They were close by!

But just as she had that idea, Erin's face fell. She could go meet them—Erin knew they were still probably in Ocre—but going there would be dangerous, wouldn't it? Everyone was still talking about the Goblin attacks and besides, Ceria and the others would probably come here instead, if Ryoka had told them where Erin was.

All she had to do was wait. And practice her alchemical cooking while she still had time. Erin knew that.

But...she didn't want to.

The sky was grey. The people wore thick clothing and walked briskly to get about their business as quickly as possible. Few people stopped to chat in the cold weather, and no one talked to Erin. She walked alone, staring at the city and feeling that this was all wrong.

This world was missing something.

Fun.

Octavia had said it: the people in this world didn't really have much fun, did they? Back home, well, Erin knew there were crummy office jobs or backbreaking jobs with bad pay all over the place. But at least people could go back home and drive to a pool, or watch videos on the computer, or play videogames or—or do things.

But here? What did the people here have to do in their spare time? As far as Erin could tell, they just kept working. They worked hard to earn more levels, or to be rich, or to enjoy themselves. But that was always for 'later', never now.

There was just something so *wrong* about this idea that Erin couldn't stand it. How could anyone live like this? Was this really what life had been like back in her world, back before the modern era?

What did people do for fun back in the Middle Ages? Erin couldn't remember. Go to festivals? See jugglers and performers? Get drunk?

This wasn't the Middle Ages of course—there was a lot more handy technology, not to mention magic. But magic seemed so far away in day-to-day life, even in Octavia's shop. Oh, there were [Mages] around who cast spells like [Message] all day, but that wasn't real *magic*. That was just more work.

If she'd been back home, what would Erin be doing right now? Thinking about college, or being in college no doubt. But if she'd just been

back at home, she would have been practicing chess, debating calling one of her friends, watching a Youtube video, talking with her pare—

Nope! Can't do that! Erin stopped in the street and slapped her cheeks hard enough for them to sting. She couldn't think about home or friends or fa—

She couldn't think about it. She'd done well so far, but being in a city full of Humans was making her nostalgic. And Erin didn't need nostalgia right now. She needed...

"A distraction."

So saying, Erin set off walking in a specific direction. She wasn't far from where she wanted to go, so in a few minutes she was pushing open the door to the Frenzied Hare.

"Miss Erin!"

A welcoming voice instantly called out her name. Erin turned, smiling, to see Miss Agnes bustle up to her, all cheer and good humor.

"Why Erin, it's a surprise to see you this early! Are you already done with your business at the [Alchemist]'s? Or—don't tell me, Miss Octavia's concocted some nasty brew that's set her store on fire again?"

"Nothing like that Miss Agnes. I just finished up early. How's Mister Jerom doing?"

Erin smiled at the older woman as she took a seat at the table. While it was true she was sort of the new boss around here—at least when it came to cooking—Miss Agnes was the one always running the inn, and Erin was gone outside of breakfast and dinner most days.

Miss Agnes smiled at Erin as she always did when Erin asked about her sick husband. Ryoka never asked, even though Erin kept reminding her to. Although...Erin wasn't sure Ryoka even remembered Mister Jerom's name, or Agnes' some days.

"He's doing as well as can be expected. Still feverish and he sleeps too much, but I'm hopeful the new alchemist's potion we bought will sort him out. We have you to thank for that of course—we'd never have been able to spare the coin if you hadn't come by."

"Oh, it's—I'm really glad I could help."

Erin smiled and waved her hand. Agnes smiled at her, and then glanced at the kitchen.

"You know, if you're done with work, I'm sure the morning crowd would love to sample your cooking—"

There it was again. Erin's smile twisted a bit on her face. It was always work, work, work. Even here.

Agnes saw Erin's expression and hurried to reassure her.

"We don't have that many guests, and I'm sure if you're not feeling up to it—"

"I'm just a bit tired today. Um, I was wondering if I could have some eggs?"

"Of course! Why, you must be tired—Maran! Some eggs for Miss Erin please!"

The [Barmaid] glanced up from one of the tables and waved at Erin in acknowledgement. Soon, she was back with the eggs, and she and Agnes sat with Erin and talked. The inn wasn't at all crowded and Safry was cooking whatever was needed in the kitchen while she served the tables as well.

Erin chewed the decent eggs with a bit of pepper and salt added for flavoring and chatted with Maran and Agnes. They didn't have much to say, to be honest. Business was good—but Erin knew that. Maran was dating another guy, a young [Cook] whom Agnes wanted to lure to the inn, but Maran wasn't even sure if they were serious about each other—soon enough, Erin felt compelled to bring up the issue on her mind.

"Hey, I've been wondering...what do you guys do for fun?"

The two women exchanged a surprised glance.

"Well, what do you mean, Erin? If you're asking about fun things to do on a date—Maran would know more about that."

Erin shook her head.

"Not like that. I mean—what do you do for fun, when you have time, I mean? Read books?"

Agnes chuckled.

"Free time? There's precious little of that here. And books? I'm sure Jerom and I don't have the coin for that, even if I wanted to spend hours reading. No, that gives me a headache."

"Then what do you do?"

Maran smiled.

"The other day I went shopping and bought a pair of earrings. The gemstones are just quartz—but they're so beautiful and they sparkle in the light! I'll show you tomorrow."

"Okay. But...did you do anything else?"

The young woman blinked.

“Anything else? I didn’t have time to do anything else.”

“Oh. Well...what else do you do for fun?”

Maran and Agnes looked confused, but they told Erin what they did when they had a day off for whatever reason.

“I have been known to have a pint or two when the dinner rush is slow—usually with Jerom—”

“I’ll dance in any tavern, that is, if I haven’t been on my feet all day—”

“There’s a [Shepherd] who plays beautifully on a flute. He goes to other inns sometimes and plays—I wish I could have him here so we could listen to the music—”

Dance, drink, gamble, listen to music—Erin listened to the short list and felt the small hole in her heart grow wider. It wasn’t that any of it was bad, but it wasn’t interesting either. Her ears did perk up when she heard Maran mention a familiar word, though.

“Oh? You have holidays here too?”

“Of course! We have a few every year, and everyone looks forward to them.”

Apparently, even Agnes would close up her inn most of the day on such occasions. The entire city would celebrate special days in the year, a lot of them right around the time holidays were observed in Erin’s world.

“The real fun is during one of the festivals. There’s candied apples, games to play, entertainments bought by the city, and so much to do! The Winter Solstice is coming up—there’s always a good time to be had then.”

“And it’s such a romantic time as well.”

Maran sighed wistfully, and Erin suspected a certain [Cook] had been chosen to share that special day with. Agnes smiled mischievously.

“Of course, there’s another way some folks entertain themselves each night—”

“Miss Agnes!”

The [Barmaid] raised her voice in shocked outrage, and Agnes laughed. Both women looked at Erin—she looked just as unimpressed.

“Oh. Right.”

That’s it? Of course, Erin got the attraction, but besides festivals, was there really nothing else to do? Flummoxed by Erin’s indifference, Agnes and Maran tried to come up with other things that were fun to do.

“There’s always a good time when a [Troubadour], [Bard], [Tumbler], or some other person with a class like that visits. I always try and go see them if I have the time.”

“They wander from city to city?”

It made sense, but that was just as...well, at least they were some fun people who visited now and then. But still. It seemed like people in Celum just waited a long time for fun to occur. Erin sighed, even more melancholy than before.

Agnes looked a bit worried that Erin was so down.

“Are you well, Erin dear? Would you like to have a rest, maybe?”

“Nah. I’m not tired.”

Erin pushed her empty plate back and stood up. If there was no fun to be had here, at least she could see if...

“I’m going to go see Fuzzylips. I mean...yeah, him.”

“Who? Oh, you mean Wesle? You go visit him practically every day. Has he caught your eye?”

Maran and Agnes smiled knowingly at Erin. Erin gave them a blank look.

“Not really. I just want to know if he’s found my skeleton yet.”

“Your what?”

“Hey Wesle.”

The [Guardsmen] had been napping, or maybe just resting his eyes, but he sat up in his wooden chair and looked attentive the moment he heard his name. He relaxed when he realized his superior wasn’t calling his name—and then he straightened up in his chair again when he realized Erin was standing in front of him.

“Oh, Miss Solstice! I didn’t realize—um, let me—would you like a seat?”

Fumbling at his words, blushing, Wesle stood up and offered Erin the only seat in the room. His. Erin just laughed at him until they left the small room which was meant for—well, probably napping [Guardsmen]—and talked.

“I didn’t expect you to be here so soon. Ah, what can I do for you, Miss Erin?”

“Any news about Toren?”

Wesle was ready for the question, because Erin asked it every day. He shook his head ruefully.

“You mean the skeleton? No, Miss Erin. I haven’t heard any of the cities reporting any sighting of the undead—and I did send out a request asking if any reports had been logged with the Adventurer’s Guilds as well.”

“Oh.”

Erin knew that was the response she’d likely get, but she sagged anyways. No one had seen Toren. Selys would have messaged her if he’d appeared around Liscor, but he hadn’t gone back there. And no one had mentioned seeing a walking skeleton around the cities either—it was like he’d disappeared.

Where was Toren now? And when she finally found him...would Erin really have to do what she was thinking? Maybe Pisces could help. But he wasn’t here yet.

Awkwardly, Wesle patted Erin on the shoulder. She smiled at him.

“That’s too bad. Thanks for looking, though.”

Wesle hesitated.

“Are you sure you won’t sit? You seem less spirited than usual, Miss Erin.”

“Really? I’m sorta...tired, I guess. You seem tired too.”

The [Guardsmen] hesitated, and then nodded with a grimace.

“It’s Esthelm, Miss. Or rather, after that all the [Guardsmen] in every city are working around the clock.”

“In case the Goblins attack?”

“That, and trying to find out *when* they’ll attack, or at least, where they are.”

Wesle gestured to a large map that had been pinned to a wall of the City Watch barracks. It had a lot of colored pins in it, most of them centered around a red cross over what had been Esthelm. Erin’s stomach twisted a bit just looking at the map.

What about Rags? Another friend she couldn’t do anything for. She let Wesle explain the problem, hoping Rags wasn’t with any of the Goblins he was talking about.

“It’s not like there are Goblins everywhere now, but there are certainly more of them. Just the other day a village near Esthelm – Verdun – reported seeing a group of a hundred or so armed Goblins.”

The man showed Erin a small pin on the map. She stared at it and looked at how close it was to Liscor and Celum. A hundred Goblins? How many did Rags have...?

“These ones aren’t like the normal groups of Goblins. They all have weapons and armor—and they move and fight like they’re actual [Soldiers]. If the village didn’t have walls, I think they’d have been attacked. But the Goblins were moving north, and luckily no one was killed.”

“Are they attacking something?”

“I think it’s a war between Goblin tribes, Miss. It happens. Or—it could be this Goblin Lord we’ve been hearing rumors about.”

Wesle’s face was grim. Erin remembered that Goblin Lords were supposed to be really bad.

“You guys are working hard. Um. Do you work like this every day?”

“Well, most days we just arrest petty criminals and patrol, Miss. Or stand watch at the gate and check travelers coming in, like we did with you. It’s not always this exciting.”

The [Guardsmen] gave Erin a faint grin. She nodded.

“And what about fun?”

“Fun, Miss?”

“Yeah. Do you do...anything for fun in your free time?”

“Weeeell...”

Wesle looked uncomfortable. Suddenly encouraged, Erin grinned and nudged him.

“Come on. What do you do? Show me, please? I won’t tell.”

It took a bit of coaxing, but eventually Wesle led Erin behind the barracks and into the practice yard. It was for [Guardsmen] to swing a blade, but the bored men and women of the City Watch had installed an unauthorized addition to the place.

A horseshoe, rusted and battered from use, swung from Wesle’s hand. He tossed it across the snowy and muddy ground and landed it near, but not on, the metal pole that had been hammered into the earth. He offered one to Erin, but she just stared at it. Erin looked at the horseshoe, and then at Wesle’s face.

“And this is what you do for fun?”

“Yeah.”

Erin stared at the horseshoes. She stared at Wesle. Then she reached out and patted him gently on the shoulder.

“I’m so sorry.”

“Er, why?”

He never got an answer. Erin just walked away, shaking her head sadly.

Such a boring world. It actually amazed Erin that she could think that. But at times, it was true. Even here, there was boredom. Perhaps more boredom than back home.

Or—maybe it wasn’t the world that was boring, but some of the people living in it. Erin had never felt bored in Liscor, but she’d always had something to do. Here, she was just an observer, watching people live lives that—weren’t that interesting, to be honest.

Wesle was a [Guardsmen]. Agnes was an [Innkeeper]. Octavia was an [Alchemist]. That was all they were and would be, and they leveled up and worked and lived, and that was all.

It wasn’t enough for Erin. She needed something else. But she had no idea of where to find it, so Erin just started walking. She walked out of the City Watch’s guardhouse and into the city, looking for something she wasn’t sure existed.

Where should she go? Erin came to a crossroads and turned left for no particular reason. She’d gone walking through the city before of course, but that was always with Ryoka. Today Erin walked down streets Ryoka would never turn.

It wasn’t that her friend was a snob—even though she sort of was. But it was that Ryoka always went from A to Z, and never bothered talking to H or exploring any places in between.

When she was in the city, Ryoka would just go to the marketplace—that was to say, the marketplace where people traded for gold and valuable items. She wouldn’t ever visit the stalls that sold Miss Agnes food, or venture into the poorer parts of the city.

Unless she was on a delivery. But most of Ryoka’s clients were rich, so she never ran down the streets Erin now walked down. The girl saw the way the buildings changed from stone to wood, the way their architecture became simpler, and the rare glass windows disappeared altogether.

And then—Erin was in a different world. She stared around at the faces of people who weren’t rich, or even close to it. She saw thin bodies, clothes

that were badly patched or simply holey, and felt something different in her chest besides apathy.

These were poor people. Of course, it shouldn't surprise Erin. Every world had poor people—people who couldn't afford to eat. But she'd somehow forgotten that they existed here. Forgotten, because she'd never looked.

A girl passing by Erin looked like she could have used a few more meals. Erin tried not to stare, but she felt a...a kinship with the people who passed her by. She'd been like that, once. She'd had nothing, living in an empty inn that was falling apart.

And of course, there was no fun to be had here. Erin looked around and only saw misery mixed with desperation. Here were people who couldn't even think about having fun. They lived on the edge.

It made her feel bad about complaining. Erin wavered, turned to go. She couldn't feed these people, but maybe if she had scraps left over from cooking? But Maran and Safry took those back to their families. No one had too much. But was there something...?

Then Erin saw it. There were shops down this street as well, and the girl she'd passed had gone to one of them, to buy something at the stalls. But while she was waiting in the queue, a small shape moved furtively behind her. Erin recognized the young boy's face at once. She'd seen him calling out to her when she'd entered the city, all innocence and smiles.

And now...he was picking a pocket. Or rather, cutting a purse. Erin saw him reaching for the young woman's money pouch hidden just under her tunic and shouted.

"Grev!"

Every head turned, but the boy's turned fastest. Grev's eyes widened when he saw Erin, and then his face went dead white with recognition. The girl he'd been trying to rob turned and shrieked in horror when she saw the small knife in his hands, but it fell from nerveless fingers as Grev stared at Erin. Erin took one step towards him, and he ran.

"Oh no you don't! Get back here!"

She ran after him, dashing past surprised people as Grev screamed and ran for his life. Erin didn't know what she'd do when she caught him—hadn't she threatened to shove a bee up his butt? She didn't have any bees left, but she wasn't too bothered by that. She was bored, and here was something to do.

Grev ran as if Carn Wolves were on his back, pushing past people, ignoring their curses. Erin ran a bit slower, dodging around people.

“Whoops! Sorry! Excuse me!”

She had Grev in her sights the entire time—until the boy turned down an alley! Erin skidded into it, wary for a second of an ambush, but she saw Grev turning around a corner. He was still running, so Erin gave chase.

Really, she had no idea why she was still running after him, but after five minutes of pursuit giving up was no longer an option. Erin *had* to catch Grev; it was a matter of pride.

Erin dashed down another poor street, practically unpaved and full of run down houses. Where was she? But there was Grev, trying to open a door!

“Gotcha!”

Before the frantic boy could open the door and get away, Erin seized him by one hand. He *shrieked* in fear and to Erin’s surprise, raised his other arm as he shrunk to the ground. As if he was afraid she would...hit...him...

She’d just processed that thought when Erin heard a voice.

“Stop, please!”

Someone grabbed her arm. The hand wasn’t big, but the touch was rough and whoever had grabbed her had *claws*. Erin jumped and let go of Grev. He ran behind his savior, a female Drake—

Erin blinked. She stared at the young Drake standing in front of her, holding a bundle of what looked like wet clothing in one claw while the other held Erin. The Drake let go of Erin and backed away instantly. She shielded Grev with her body as she spoke desperately to Erin.

“Please, Miss! Don’t hurt him! He’s just a child!”

“Wha?”

Why was a Drake in Celum? Erin hadn’t even seen one, but here was a Drake, standing in front of her. The Drake paused as she realized Erin wasn’t going to start hitting her. For a moment she and Erin just stared at each other while Grev hid behind her, sniveling.

“You’re a Drake.”

That was the brilliant opening Erin came up with. The female Drake hesitated, and then nodded. She bit at her lip, glaring at Erin as if that statement was a challenge.

“That’s right. I’m a Drake. But I live here, and the Watch knows about me.”

“Oh.”

“I’m sorry if Grev did anything—but he’s just a child! Please, whatever he did—”

“He was pickpocketing. I saw him.”

The Drake’s reaction was immediate, as was Grev’s. He immediately let go of her and piped up in denial.

“I never!”

“Oh Grev—”

She stared at him, clearly knowing he was lying. But instantly the Drake looked back at Erin, and now there was a genuine note of desperation in her voice.

“Please don’t report him, Miss. Please don’t. He’s only one crime away from being exiled from the city. And if that happens—it was just one mistake, Miss. It won’t happen again.”

“Really?”

Erin propped her hands on her hips and stared at Grev as he tried to turn invisible.

“I happen to have met Grev before. He helped a bunch of thugs ambush me when I first came into the city.”

“*Grev!*”

The Drake turned. To Erin’s surprise, she dropped the clothing on the snowy cobblestones and grabbed Grev, lifting him up as he shouted.

“I—I—”

“*How dare you!* I’ll spank you until you won’t sit for two weeks! And you’re not having dinner! I should drag you to the City Watch myself. Do you want to be kicked out of the city? Because if you do—”

“I’m sorry! *I’m sorry I’m sorry I’m—*”

The Drake kept shaking Grev as he apologized frantically, shouting. Erin saw other doors opening and closing once the occupants saw what was going on, but no one came to see. She cleared her throat and the two stopped and stared at her.

Grev’s face was somewhere beyond white and going into ghostly. The Drake’s face was—well, her dark red scales couldn’t really change color like skin, but they were definitely looking more pink than red around her face. Both clearly expected the worst.

And why not? Erin wasn’t a huge, angry [Warrior], true, but she was dressed a lot better than they were, and she could easily summon the Watch.

But to their surprise, the young woman didn't shout or get angry. She just smiled a bit, and held out a hand.

"I'm Erin. Who are you?"

The Drake stared at the hand, and then dropped Grev. She gingerly took the hand.

"Jasi. My name is Jasi, Miss."

Jasi the Drake was one of perhaps two or three Drakes in Celum.

"I don't know. There was a [Merchant], but he might have left. And there's a [Baker] who married a Human woman. But it's not common, especially in small cities like this."

"Really?"

Jasi shifted in her seat. Erin was sitting in her home—hers and Grev's. Apparently, they lived in a squalid hut—house was too grand a word for this place—next to the city walls. It had belonged to their parents, both of whom were dead or had simply left. Erin hadn't asked.

Now Erin sat on a rickety chair with a cup of boiled water in front of her. She hadn't drunk from it. There were a few flecks in the water that she didn't want in her stomach. Jasi sat across from her while Grev tried to listen to their conversation and hide in the other corner of the room.

Talking had happened. And spanking and apologizing and now explanations were currently occurring.

"You live pretty close to Liscor. I'd have thought more than one or two Drakes would live in cities, even Human ones."

"Well...people don't like Drakes here. And I've heard that most Drakes don't like Humans."

Jasi looked uncomfortable as she spoke. She'd apologized a hundred times to Erin, but she was still clearly afraid Erin would go ballistic over Grev's crimes, or, Erin realized, her being a Drake. She tried to reassure the young...woman.

"Don't worry—I don't mind Drakes. In fact, I live in Liscor where there are tons of them!"

"Liscor?"

Both Grev and Jasi exclaimed at the same time. Jasi looked at Erin with wide eyes.

“Really? But I heard Humans don’t live there. Unless—are you an adventurer, Miss?”

“Nope.”

“She is!”

Grev called out from one corner of the room. He was standing—as sitting would be very hard with his sore backside. He flinched when Erin and Jasi looked at him. But he piped up with the determination to be proved right.

“I saw her! She beat three big men by herself! She punched one of them so hard she broke his nose!”

“And whose fault is it she had to fight you *stupid*—”

Jasi raised her voice and nearly got up before Erin stopped her. She was all for punishing Grev, but he’d had enough, at least in her opinion.

“I’m not an adventurer. I’m an [Innkeeper]. I have an inn in Liscor and I happen to have a few combat Skills.”

“Oh.”

“Did you come from Liscor?”

Jasi suddenly turned red, the scales around her face actually turning a lighter pink rather than darkening.

“Who me? No—I’ve actually never been to Liscor. Or...or anywhere with other Drakes, really.”

“What? Then how...?”

“It’s a long story, Miss.”

It came out as the cup of water in front of Erin slowly stopped steaming and went cold. It was cold in Jasi’s house, and it was her house. Erin had figured out some of the story just seeing how Jasi and Grev interacted, but the rest fell into place quickly enough.

Jasi was adopted. Or more accurately, she was a child that had been abandoned and found and raised by a Human father and mother. She’d lived in Celum all her life, but that life hadn’t been kind to her. Her parents—who’d taken care of her and taught her to live among Humans and then had Grev—had split up unhappily. The mother found another man, the father just...disappeared one day.

It was a sad story, the kind Erin had heard many times in her world. But to hear it here—was disheartening. But what Erin could admire throughout it was Jasi. She’d kept going even when her parents had gone. She’d found

work, as a [Washer] although she only had a handful of levels, and she'd earned enough coin for her and Grev to survive.

The catch was that she couldn't look after Grev and earn money at the same time. The street had raised him, and what Grev had learned was how to steal, and how to lure innocent people into ambushes. Jasi had known about the first part and done her best to stop that, but she hadn't known about the muggings.

When Erin gave her the full recounting of what Grev had done when she'd first met him—and after she'd stopped threatening to bite Grev's hands off, Jasi got down on her hands and knees and begged Erin for mercy.

"I swear to you, I'll never let it happen again. *Please* don't report him. He's the only family I have left."

What could Erin do but agree? Jasi made Grev apologize a hundred times, and promised to keep a better watch over him, but all Erin could wonder was when he'd be caught next, and what would happen then.

And from the look in Jasi's eyes, she was thinking the same thing. That was how Erin found herself sitting in their grubby home, poking a finger into the very cold cup of water and watching as Jasi got back to her work.

She washed clothing for bronze coins, day in, day out. And she did it by using a tub of quite dirty water in the cold home and using lye soap and her claws to scrub the dirty fabrics as clean as she could.

It was hard, backbreaking work, especially since Jasi didn't exactly have any racks to dry the clothes on, let alone a washer and dryer. Instead, she hung bits of rope from stands—chairs, the ceiling, and so on, letting the clothing drip-dry as the small fire she kept going in the fireplace added smoke to the cold room.

Erin didn't know if she liked Jasi. She certainly felt bad for her, but that wasn't the same as liking her. But she felt she couldn't just walk out of the home. Not when she looked at Jasi's hands, or rather, her claws.

Her scales were paler and—damaged around her claws. Some were even missing, revealing pale white skin underneath. It was clearly painful from the way the Drake girl avoided brushing up against the exposed parts where she could. Erin could only guess that her work washing clothes had scraped away her scales one at a time.

It was like...seeing how her life could have gone. Maybe. Jasi was a stranger in a city full of people who weren't like her, and didn't *like* her.

And what was more, she had to take care of Grev. It was a thankless, soul crushing task. And Erin...

Erin felt at her belt pouch. She had gold coins and silver coins in there, courtesy of her work as an [Innkeeper] at Miss Agnes' inn. She had more bronze coins than Jasi and Grev had together. If she gave them just one gold coin, what would happen?

Happiness, perhaps for a day? Then it would be back to normal. Maybe Jasi could buy something to help her with washing, but the place they were in wouldn't change that much.

What about all the coins? They'd probably get robbed. And even then, when it ran out they'd still be poor. Erin was no social worker, no expert in charity and relief management, but she knew this wasn't a good option.

But what else could be done? She could...walk out and leave them alone. But Erin rejected that as well. And yet—how many people were like Jasi? If Erin went next door, she was sure she'd probably feel the exact same way about the people living there.

But she knew Jasi, and Grev. She knew their names. That made things different. Just knowing their names meant it was so hard to walk away.

"Grev! Help me lift this, will you? And don't drop it or I'll have to wash it again!"

Jasi snapped at Grev as she struggled to lift some wet shirts up. Erin sat back down as Grev ran over. She watched them work.

Yes. If she helped them half-heartedly, she wouldn't change much, would she? But if she gave them everything, what would happen to her?

What would Ryoka do? Would she come up with a brilliant solution, or would she just shake her head and say this is how the world was and walk away? Erin didn't know.

She saw the female Drake wince as the clothing wrapped around a patch of exposed skin where the scales had been torn away. But she made no sound.

Erin looked at the windows. The shutters were closed—obviously they had no glass windows, but even the shutters had gaps in them, letting in the winter air. And the floor was filthy. When had they last cleaned? And the water in the tub—Jasi must have hauled it here, and when would she be able to replace it? Only when it became impossible to wash with, Erin bet.

So hard. Hard, and—and small. This was all they had, and even that was uncertain. Erin's heart ached as she looked at Grev, reluctantly helping Jasi

hang up clothes to dry by the fire. She thought, and came to a decision, even though it might have been the wrong one.

“Miss Erin...what’s this?”

That was what Agnes said when Erin brought Jasi and Grev to the inn. They stared at the bustling place, wide-eyed and disbelieving, an expression that was mirrored on Agnes’ face when Erin told her what she intended.

“You want to hire her as a [Barmaid]? Well of course we could use the help but—does she have any levels in the class? And what about the boy?”

“Grev can stay here. He can’t work, but he can sleep here. I don’t know what he’ll do every day—I’ll think of something to keep him out of trouble.”

Jasi bobbed a nervous curtsy to Miss Agnes.

“I’ll work hard, Miss. If you need me to haul things or clean up—I can do that. Anything you need.”

“I—well—we’ll see.”

Agnes looked helplessly at Erin. She gave the uncertain Jasi and Grev a big smile and had them sit at a table.

“We’ll—have Safry bring you some food. You two look like you could use some. Safry! And then we’ll put you to work, Miss Jasi.”

As the two sat and Safry came over, Agnes drew Erin aside and spoke to her in a troubled voice.

“I hate to question you, but—do you know what you’re doing, Erin? This seems...sudden. Have you thought all this through?”

“No. Not really.”

Miss Agnes looked somewhat dismayed by Erin’s honest response. But the truth of it was that Erin herself was uncertain. When she’d stood up and announced that Jasi could work at her inn, it had felt right. But now—

“I know you come from Liscor where Drakes are common—but here Drakes are—well, there’s history—”

“I know, Miss Agnes. But I had to do something.”

“You have a kind heart, Erin. I know that.”

But you made a mistake. Erin heard it unspoken in Agnes’ voice. She ignored it.

“For now just have Jasi wait tables. That’s easy. And Grev can eat and sit in a corner.”

So passed the first night. Erin kept an eye on Jasi, and especially Grev. But Grev was meek and even grateful for the food, eating a huge amount until Erin thought he would be sick. But he eventually just passed out in a minor food coma at his table.

As for Jasi, she still seemed stunned to work at such a busy inn. She was constantly serving tables, bringing the food Erin cooked out of the kitchen. And even if she got quite a few glances, Erin heard no audible comments, at least, not while she was in the common room.

She cooked, fried, and served food in her own world of anxiety. Then, when the last of the guests had eaten, Erin found a small room for Jasi and Grev to sleep in.

“I don’t know how to thank you, Miss Erin. Are you sure it’s alright for us to be sleeping here? We have a house—”

“I’m sure. And this way you can help in the morning.”

Erin smiled at Jasi and Grev, keeping her emotions inside of her until they’d closed the door. Then she went to her own room and sat on her bed and put her head in her hands.

“Was that a mistake?”

It felt like it. Erin hated to say it out loud, but she wasn’t sure. What had she just done? It had been so sudden, an impulse decision.

“But what was I *thinking*?”

Making Jasi a [Barmaid]? Offering her a job? It had seemed like the only option Erin could take. The obvious choice. But now that she was here

It wasn’t a good fit. Jasi would work hard, but Erin had seen the looks the patrons of the inn gave her. She was a Drake, and unpopular. Plus, she would have to start at Level 1 and work her way up as a [Barmaid]. Agnes had expressed her doubts, and no wonder. Did Agnes even like Jasi? What about Maran and Safry? Would they be afraid Jasi would take their jobs or steal their wages since Erin had hired her? What about when Erin was gone? Would Agnes fire Jasi then and there?

And when Erin left...could she take Jasi with her? Would the Drake be willing to go back to Liscor? What about Grev? He wouldn’t be happy in that city, and the Liscorian City Watch was hard on crime, especially by Humans.

Especially after Lyonette.

Erin tossed and turned in her bed. She knew she'd made a bad choice. But could she just leave them there? But now—she'd taken them out of their home. What could she do? Jasi might have lost her job since Erin had taken her away! Could Erin just give her money and tell her to go back if things didn't work out?

She didn't know. Erin lay sleepless in her bed, trying to figure out what the right answer was. But she was only sure of one thing. One simple thing: of all the things she could have done, the worst thing would have been nothing.

She'd made her choice. Now she would help Jasi—and Grev—as much as she could. That was all she could do.

Exhausted, but knowing she had to sleep, Erin finally closed her eyes. She mumbled to herself as sleep finally overwhelmed her stressed brain.

“At the very least...I have something to do.”

She closed her eyes and slept.

[Innkeeper Level 27!]

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3.16

She wished she had an iPod. That's what Erin thought when she woke up in her small bed on the second floor of Miss Agnes' inn. It was probably because she'd made the mistake of thinking about home yesterday.

Ryoka had her iPhone. She'd kept it even though she'd gone to a whole new world. Whereas Erin hadn't. True, she didn't usually bring her phone on bathroom breaks, but if she ever got back she'd take one everywhere she went. And she'd bring an emergency backpack of everything—

If she ever went back. Erin slapped her head.

“Stop!”

Nothing good happened when she thought about home. The only thing that ever happened was—well, weeping and moping and crippling desperation. That's why Erin had stopped thinking about it on purpose, starting all those days ago when she'd cried herself to sleep in a broken inn in the middle of nowhere.

She was here, and she had to survive. Erin got up and dressed herself blearily. She couldn't smile—she felt weighed down by heavy thoughts. And she felt even more tired when she remembered her new employee.

“What do I do? What did you do, stupid Erin?”

She gently thumped her head against a wall. Someone grunted in the next room and Erin winced.

“Oops.”

There was no going back. She could only do what was right. And what was right was—

Erin came down the stairs with a determined smile on her face. She'd find something Jasi could do. She'd help her succeed as a [Barmaid]—or do something else. Because even if Erin couldn't help everyone, she would never leave the Drake and her brother alone. If she did, she wouldn't be Erin Solstice.

And yet—not everyone was like her. That was why Erin's smiled twisted the instant she walked down into the common room of the inn and saw what was happening.

“Oh, Erin, my dear!”

Miss Agnes looked up from the table where she was sitting with Jasi. Across the room, Erin saw Safry cleaning the tables before the day started and the one or two early guests waiting for breakfast. Erin looked around the room as she descended the steps. Grev was nowhere to be seen.

“Miss Agnes. And Jasi. What’s happening? And where’s Grev?”

Jasi gave Erin a warm, but—uncomfortable—smile. She was sitting somewhat tensely in front of Miss Agnes, and Erin could tell the other [Innkeeper] was—

“What’s all this?”

Miss Agnes didn’t seem to notice the edge in Erin’s tone. She smiled at Erin, beamed, rather, like she always did.

“Well, I was just having a chat with Jasi about her future.”

“Her future? What do you mean, Miss Agnes?”

“Oh, I was thinking about it all night. And I had a chat with Jerom—you did a wonderful thing, helping Jasi and Grev. But although I’m sure she’d be a wonderful [Barmaid], I thought we could explore all her options. After all, Jasi’s so young—I wouldn’t want her to level up in a class that didn’t fit her perfectly, would I?”

For two seconds, because she’d had a bad time waking up and because she’d been hanging out with Ryoka too long, Erin thought about punching Miss Agnes in the face. But she suppressed that instinct at once.

“I see. You want to help Jasi find a job. Another job.”

“Well, I was just thinking how nice it would be if she could find a class she really liked. Being a [Barmaid] isn’t for everyone, and if we can find something that suits her better...”

Miss Agnes met Erin’s eyes innocently. But the message was clear. And it was infuriating to Erin.

Jasi hadn’t even been here one whole day, and Miss Agnes had decided that her inn was not for the Drake. And better yet—she’d talked it over with Mister Jerom, her husband, had she? Erin had visited the sick [Innkeeper] and she knew any conversation Agnes had with him was completely one-sided. She probably just chattered on to him as he groaned in bed and coughed up phlegm.

“So you’ve been helping Jasi since you woke up? That was kind of you.”

“Well, I had time. And I was waiting for you to be up so we could start with breakfast—you really have a talent for cooking, my dear!”

“You mean a Skill. Where’s Grev?”

Normally Erin met most things with a good attitude. But this morning she wasn’t in the mood for niceness. Agnes blinked at her.

“Oh. I sent him outside to play. I’m sure he’ll be back when he’s hungry. Young boys always live by their stomachs.”

And how would Miss Agnes know that? *She’d* never had a kid. Of course, Erin hadn’t ever had one either, but there was just something about the other innkeeper that was rubbing Erin the wrong way today.

It was just that she’d decided to kick Jasi out. The Drake clearly understood what the [Innkeeper]’s intentions were, no matter how much she smiled, and she looked justifiably upset. Erin glanced across the room and saw Safry glance at her and then quickly away. Safry knew what was going on. Did Maran? Had this been agreed on by all three women or just Agnes?

Who knew? Erin could only move forwards, and so she smiled at Agnes and Jasi.

“Well, I’d love to help with that.”

“But breakfast—”

Miss Agnes coughed delicately and Erin frowned.

“It can wait. Or better yet, this can wait.”

“Oh, it’s no trouble my dear. I’m perfectly willing to help young Jasi out while you cook.”

Erin gritted her teeth. There was an...air about Agnes. It was almost written on her face ‘let’s help the children find what they’re good at so I won’t have to deal with them!’ It made her upset, and even angrier that Agnes was deliberately sending Erin into the kitchen to cook.

She wanted to object. Erin opened her mouth, but the problem was—Agnes was right. Erin needed to make breakfast for the hungry masses who’d soon be coming here for her good cooking. And yet—she didn’t want to leave Jasi alone with Agnes.

But was it really a problem? Erin thought about that for a moment. It wasn’t as if Agnes was kicking Jasi out this moment. She was going to work with Jasi—even if it was selfish. Would it be that bad to let her help?

Well...yes and no. Agnes would certainly help because it meant Jasi and Grev would be out of her hair. But she’d probably not look for the best class to suit them—she’d probably compromise instantly and choose whatever they were good at without exploring all the options.

But she would help. It just meant Erin would have to make sure Agnes didn't rush things along. And it meant that Miss Agnes wasn't the person Erin had thought she was.

She was just a woman. Good to her friends and family, but no better than that. It wasn't a crushing realization, but it just made Erin's heart hurt a bit.

She let none of that show on her face as she smiled at Agnes.

"Good idea. I'll make breakfast, and then come back and help Jasi. I hope you're hungry."

"Oh? Are you planning on making something special today?"

Agnes smiled at Erin. Erin smiled back.

"Mm. I think I'll make some crepes and French toast. And bacon."

Miss Agnes hesitated. Erin had chosen one of the most popular breakfasts for today—mainly because it was a new form of cooking. It certainly brought in customers, but it was a very work-intensive meal for the staff to serve, as customers would regularly order second or even third helpings.

"Oh. Well, Maran isn't here today—"

"No problem! You and Jasi can help if Safry needs it. That's why she's here, isn't it?"

"I—well—"

Erin walked into the kitchen. There she deliberately cooked the best crepes she could and made sure the *sizzle* and smell of cooking bacon would wake up even the most reluctant sleeper. She derived no small amount of pleasure from making Agnes' inn the most profitable and busy building in the city that morning, and felt not a bit bad as Agnes, Safry, and Jasi hurried to fill orders.

It was all about food. Food was one of the things that was popular in any world. Erin reflected on that as she flipped a crepe into the air and onto a plate. She put it aside to cool, and then changed her mind and speared a piece of it with a fork and popped it into her mouth, ignoring the heat. Breakfast for Erin was usually in the middle of her cooking process.

"Five more crepes, Miss Erin!"

Safry poked her head into the kitchen, looking distressed. Erin could hear the voices in the common room, lots of them.

"Coming up!"

She poured and flipped, barely paying attention to what she was doing. Crepes. Now, weren't crepes interesting?

The people of this world knew about pancakes, but crepes were new to them. But why did they pull in huge crowds even a week after Erin had introduced them to Celum? The answer was simple: they were new.

Yes, crepes had all the ingredients of a pancake except for baking powder. But it was what you did with the crepes—folding them and pouring syrup over them, or filling them with whipped cream or other savory and sweet things that made them so special. In that way, an old thing seemed practically brand new, and people flocked to the Frenzied Hare to try this wonderful food Erin made.

By now, Erin knew other inns and restaurants across the city were copying her recipe. It was human nature—and Drake and Gnoll nature as well. In time, she knew crepes would lose their hold over the stomachs of people and they'd just become one more item in a menu. But right now they were hot.

“Literally. Safry! Crepes are done!”

Because they were new. Erin let Safry take the plates as she placed some bacon on a plate next to eggs. People liked new things. Like her hamburgers. When they first came to Liscor, it was like they were the greatest food in the world. Because no one had tried them before. As soon as everyone started copying her recipe, hamburgers became, well, hamburgers. Some people loved them and they were tasty, but no one was lining up for them.

But new food was fun. That was the point. New *things* were fun. Erin remembered the impromptu concert she'd held outside her inn and smiled. Music from her world was so new and amazing to the citizens of Liscor she'd pulled in the gold coins with a rake.

Because it was new. Because it wasn't stale and mundane and boring. That was the key. Erin still remembered her despondency from yesterday—in truth, it was still bugging her a bit, although the Jasi and Grev situation had distracted her. Music and food were two things people in this world could appreciate, same as in Erin's. But—

It wasn't enough. It still wasn't enough. Erin could see someone like Agnes listening to the latest hot song of the year being played on the lute—or delighting over some new recipe and selling it at her inn. But was that all she'd ever do? Just stuff her face and listen to a new tune now and then?

No. That was so *boring* it hurt. There had to be more to life! People weren't machines—Erin refused to believe that leveling up like machines every day and working without any fun was how this world should be.

That was why when she walked back out of the kitchen and saw that the inn had mostly cleared, Erin was determined to find Jasi a job that wouldn't crush the Drake's soul. She'd already accepted that Jasi wouldn't be a [Barmaid]—at least not at Agnes' inn. If the woman didn't want her here, then that was that.

But Erin could always bring Jasi to Liscor. It wasn't the best option, but Erin kept it as a reserve idea. She walked over to the exhausted Agnes, who'd taken a seat at the table to rest her legs, and smiled brightly.

"Alright! Breakfast's done. Let's find Jasi a cool class."

Agnes only smiled weakly at Erin.

"Oh. Very good, dear."

How did one find a class? It was such an odd question to Erin—was it like getting a job in her world, or did someone just decide to become a [Thief] and start stealing things?

As it turned out, people in this world decided on classes in a very sensible manner. Once Miss Agnes had recovered, Erin found herself sitting at the table with her and Jasi as the older woman quizzed the Drake on her likes and dislikes.

"Do you sew? I should say—have you tried needlework? What about cooking? I hear your kind has a variety of...interesting treats."

Likes, dislikes, and most importantly natural talent or aptitude went into choosing a class. Which made sense. No one wanted to be stuck with a class they were bad at, or one they hated. Jasi had taken the [Washer] class out of desperation, so Agnes and Erin's job was to find something she'd like and be good at, and hopefully, earn enough to support herself and Grev with.

The problem was, Jasi didn't seem to have any outstanding talents.

"I poke my scales more often than the cloth with needles. I would have sewn if I could—mending clothes earns a bit more coin than washing. But I couldn't do it. The same goes for cooking—I can make a few things, but kneading dough is hard with claws."

“Ooh. Yeah. That wouldn’t be so easy.”

Miss Agnes frowned slightly in vexation at Jasi, and partly at Erin. She was clearly irritable from having to play [Barmaid] so early.

“Have you ever thought about a combat class, dear? I know that’s a long shot, but...”

“I hate fighting.”

Jasi shook her head immediately, shuddering at the thought. Agnes nodded.

“Well, those classes are out, then.”

The older woman sighed. Jasi looked anxiously at her and Erin.

“I really don’t mind trying to learn to sew or cook. Or—I thought I could even learn a class like [Butcher] or [Receptionist]. I’m not picky. I’d try anything if I had the chance.”

“That’s the spirit!”

Agnes immediately brightened up at Jasi’s words.

“We could try you out in all of those professions. I have friends in various classes—it wouldn’t be too hard to talk them into giving you an apprenticeship. Why, in a day or two you’d probably find something you really shine at.”

Jasi nodded obediently, looking grateful for the opportunity, but Erin frowned.

“Willing doesn’t mean she *likes* it, Miss Agnes. Jasi should find a job—a class that suits her.”

“Yes, well, we don’t all know what we’ll be good at.”

Agnes smiled blandly at Erin. There was definitely a current of tension running between the two [Innkeepers] now, or so Erin felt. No—she wasn’t imagining it. She was annoyed at Agnes, and the same held true of the other woman. They were clashing over the issue of Jasi, and it was making Erin uncharacteristically upset.

“I think a few days of feeling things out would do young Jasi some good, Erin.”

“Really?”

“It helped me. I didn’t know I’d be an [Innkeeper] when I was young. But when I met Jerom, well, things have a way of working themselves out. We don’t all get to choose what class we level in, now do we? You told me you earned your [Innkeeper] class by accident as well. Maybe Jasi will find her class as she tries things out.”

Erin narrowed her eyes. Being an [Innkeeper] certainly hadn't been her choice, but she'd been forced into it out of the need to survive, and because she'd liked it.

"I don't know. I think we should consider more classes. There are tons more than just...those ones you mentioned."

Miss Agnes lost her smile. She sounded exasperated as she spread her hands out on the table.

"The girl—the Drake—doesn't have any particular skills, Erin. Why not let her work a few odd jobs? She seemed to be doing well for herself as a [Washer] before you came along."

Jasi shrunk back in her seat, but Erin didn't bat an eye at the criticism.

"If you mean she was alive, yeah, she was. But I had to buy a healing potion for her hands. That's not doing okay, Miss Agnes."

The woman wavered. She glanced around the mostly empty room and realized their argument had attracted a few casual eyes. Safry immediately turned and started bussing a few more tables. Miss Agnes eyed the new customers and changed the subject.

"We've got more customers, I see."

"So we do."

Erin folded her arms. Miss Agnes waffled on, glancing meaningfully at Erin.

"Late morning breakfasters, I'll warrant. There's always one or two...a good [Innkeeper] prepares for them, but I suppose it *was* quite a crowd that came in this morning. But here we are, and I know they're hungry. It would be a shame to turn them away, don't you think?"

A scowl was the only reply she got. Erin sat in her chair, unwilling to move. She glanced at the customers, and then smiled.

"Why don't *you* cook for them?"

"Me?"

Agnes blinked.

"But I—well, I don't have any Skills in cooking like you do, Erin dear."

"But this *is* your inn. And I'm tired. So—you cook. Or you could turn them away. But I think I'm going to help Jasi some more."

So saying, Erin turned her back on Agnes and looked at Jasi. After a few seconds she heard Agnes walk briskly away.

"Safry! Ask our customers what they'd like to eat."

Erin smiled at Jasi, who looked somewhat pale.

“I don’t want to be a bother, Miss Erin, I really don’t. I’d be more than happy to apprentice at any job for a while. If I got a few levels—why, I’d probably be able to make do from there.”

The young woman sitting across from her smiled and shook her head slowly.

“That’s true. But I want to find something that *you* like to do, not something that you have to do. Agnes is wrong. You should try and find something you want to do.”

Jasi paused.

“Thank you, Miss Erin.”

For the first time this morning, Erin gave her a genuine smile.

“Call me Erin. Just Erin. Now, have you ever tried running around? I have a friend who does that all the time, and she says the pay is good...”

An hour later, Erin had to admit that perhaps Jasi *didn’t* have any particular class that seemed to suit her. At least, not one that could be easily discerned. She and Jasi had gone through a huge list of classes, hindered by Miss Agnes’ occasional comment, but Jasi either hadn’t tried the class before or didn’t feel inclined to try it.

Some jobs the Drake could tell weren’t for her. [Farmer], [Soldier], [Thief]...those were easy. Others might have been likely, but they were impossible to tell, like [Guardswoman]. How would you even tell? Jasi had never lifted a sword before. And she hadn’t had a chance to try out any of the other professions in the city.

She’d been poor all her life. And that, Erin was quickly discovering, was a limiting factor.

Despondently, Erin slumped over at her table, staring at Jasi’s helpless expression. The inn was mostly empty. Agnes’ cooking had a way of driving away even fairly hungry patrons, and besides, it was that time of day when inns didn’t really matter, in between breakfast and lunch. If people wanted a snack they’d find a stall outside. And few people were drinking this early in the day.

Erin could use a drink. She hadn’t known how *hard* this would be. Well, she had—but knowing wasn’t the same as experiencing it. She felt like she

was hitting her head against an invisible brick wall, but she had no idea how to stop running into it.

“I dunno. I guess we could do the internship-apprentice thing, but that’s so *slow*. Are you sure you don’t want to try being an [Alchemist]? I could go bother Octavia right now if you want.”

“That’s one thing I *am* sure about, Miss. [Alchemists] are far too strange for me. I don’t want to melt my tail off or—or grow mushrooms out of my eyes.”

Jasi shuddered at the thought. Erin sighed and then cast her eyes around the inn.

“What do you think, Wesle? Would Jasi be a good [Guardswoman]?”

Wesle looked up guiltily as he tucked into a crepe Erin had made. He straightened up in his chair, glancing at the door.

“I ah, don’t know, Erin. Guarding isn’t as hard here as it is in a Drake city, it’s true, but we do require all our recruits to be able to use a sword. Plus, there’s always a bit of fighting when we have to quiet drunks. If Miss Jasi was assigned to gatekeeping duty I could see her doing well—but even then, she’d have to help fight whenever a monster attacked.”

Erin nodded gloomily.

“Thought so. How’s the crepe?”

“Oh, wonderful, Miss Erin.”

Wesle blushed a bit.

“I’m very grateful. But ah, I *am* on duty. I’d better just eat this quickly and go.”

“Mm. Thanks for bringing Grev here.”

Erin turned her head and regarded the nervous young boy sitting at a table with a crepe of his own. Wesle had brought Grev into the Frenzied Hare about an hour after breakfast had ended. Now the [Guardsmen] looked over at Grev sternly, giving him a hard look.

“I hardly believed him when he said he lived here, Miss Erin. But he kept insisting that you’d given him and his…sister a place here.”

“Well, he was telling the truth. Which is sorta rare for him, I guess.”

Grev hunched over in his seat. He’d been caught by Wesle for lingering a bit too near a shopkeeper’s outdoor stall. Now he sat with the disapproving eyes of Jasi, Erin, and Wesle on him, clearly wishing he could be anywhere else.

“I’m so sorry about that, sir.”

Jasi was as apologetic as she'd been with Erin, and clearly unable to do anything to stop Grev. She was a big sister, not a mother, and she was even more nervous now that Grev had clearly not learned his lesson from yesterday.

Wesle nodded to her, trying to look dignified and failing to with bits of crepe on his weak mustache.

"I'll overlook this today, but you should know your brother is on the thinnest of ice, Miss Jasi. If he keeps sneaking off again—"

Safry was passing by Erin with a used plate and utensils. Erin snatched the plate out of her hands and hurled one of the utensils in one motion. The spoon passed by Grev's nose and bounced off one wall. He shouted in surprise and alarm, freezing as he tried to edge towards the door.

"Sit down."

Erin's glare magically sent Grev's bottom back in the chair. He trembled as she waved the fork at him.

"You've caused enough trouble for your sister. Try and run off and I'll throw the plate at you next time. And if that doesn't work, I'll take this fork and shove it—"

Erin paused. She glanced at Safry and Miss Agnes, both of whom were watching her with gaping mouths.

"What?"

Wesle coughed delicately.

"Was that [Unerring Throw], Miss Erin? It's rare to see an [Innkeeper] with a combat Skill like that."

"Oh."

Erin just shrugged. She had a lot of odd Skills, or so she'd gathered. Probably because she'd actually had to fight for her life. They weren't that useful in day-to-day life, but they were certainly handy when she wanted to terrorize young boys.

"Where were we? Oh yeah. Jasi's class. Um..."

Erin sighed. Then she looked at Grev. He stared at her, white-faced.

"What about him? Can't Grev get a class instead of running around and stealing things?"

Agnes snorted. She'd kept out of the discussion, but she eyed Grev skeptically now.

"The boy's at the right age to be apprenticed to someone. But with his past misdeeds—I doubt anyone would want to take a risk on him. I'd advise

Miss Jasi to say her goodbyes while she can—if the young thief hasn't changed his ways after so many warnings, he won't now."

Jasi's scales turned pale and Grev looked palely down at his empty plate. Erin glared at Miss Agnes.

"Don't you have anything you can do, Miss Agnes?"

"Not at the moment, Miss Erin. I have no customers, as you may have noticed."

"Then why don't you leave your inn to me for a while?"

The woman paused.

"What?"

"I said, why don't you leave? I'm perfectly capable of managing it, and I think you could use a break."

"But I—this is *my* inn."

Erin raised an eyebrow. She was royally annoyed with Miss Agnes' attitude. How could she be so uncaring? So Erin took a page out of Ryoka's book of meanness.

"It's your inn, but I'm a better [Innkeeper]. You can take a break and leave things to me. You and Safry, for that matter."

Both women gaped at Erin. But the young woman just flapped her hands at them.

"Shoo, shoo."

Miss Agnes was staring hard at Erin, but she *was* the lower-level [Innkeeper], and Erin had stared down far more frightening things than a middle-aged woman with empathy issues. In the end, Miss Agnes haughtily adjusted her dress, not meeting Erin's stare.

"I—suppose I could use some time to relax. Very well. Safry, you have the day off."

"Yes, Miss Agnes."

"I believe I'll...go shopping. I'm sure Jerom would love a new decoration. Yes, I'll do that. Thank you, Miss Erin."

She walked out of the inn. Safry hesitated, and then followed her as Erin stared at her.

"Mnn."

Erin stuck out her tongue after Miss Agnes and Safry had left. She felt bad but not-bad at the same time. It was the first time she'd ever been so mean to them, but—they'd been real jerks!

She turned and saw Wesle staring at her with a piece of crepe dangling from a fork. Jasi and Grev were also giving her fish-eyes.

“What? They were being rude.”

Jasi gulped. She looked at the door Miss Agnes hadn’t even bothered to fully close and shook her head, her scales pale around her face. She looked at Erin, mystified and gratified and upset.

“You’re being so kind to us, Mis—Erin. Too kind. I don’t know why you’re going so far for people like Grev and me.”

“It’s because I can.”

The smile Erin gave her was just that. A smile. But it made the Drake cry, and prompted Wesle to offer her a handkerchief. Grev sat in his chair, looking upset and confused, but soon enough Erin had another crepe in front of everyone, and a slightly alcoholic drink for the adults and milk for Grev. She sat down and took a deep breath.

“Okay, let’s try again. Properly this time. Jasi needs a new job. Not necessarily a class. Grev needs to stop stealing, and Wesle probably needs to get back to work, but he’s helping us. How can we make things right?”

The best idea they’d had was for Erin to sponsor Jasi as an apprentice at a bunch of different jobs. Erin put her head in her hands and groaned.

“I wish Ryoka were here.”

“Why?”

“She’d know what to do. She’s got lots of ideas.”

Wesle looked confused. He was sitting at the table with Erin and Jasi while Grev practiced the art of trying not to puke. Erin’s solution to his restlessness had been to feed him to the point of bursting. Now he was sitting at his table, unable to even finish his last bite of hash browns drizzled with cheese.

Jasi was staring at the half-empty mug in her hands. She’d been growing more and more quietly depressed throughout the discussion. Now she looked up, confused.

“Who’s Ryoka?”

“A City Runner. She’s my friend.”

“And how could she help? I’ve seen Miss Ryoka come into the city quite often, but I don’t see how she’d help here. She seemed rather—quiet

every time I tried to talk to her.”

Erin shook her head at Wesle.

“I know she’s a jerk sometimes. But she’s smart. And she studied a lot of weird stuff in school. Did you know she told me that we could probably build a greenhouse right next to my inn? She said we don’t even need any glass to make it, which is really weird, right? I was going to ask Klbkch about it, but then I ended up here.”

Almost none of what Erin had said made sense to either Wesle or Jasi. They just blinked at her, confused. She sighed.

“Never mind. Are there any classes we haven’t considered?”

“None, Miss.”

Jasi looked gloomy.

“I really do appreciate you helping, I do. But I don’t think I have any special talents. I’d be happy with a steady job, I really would.”

“Yeah, but that’s so…”

The [Innkeeper]’s voice trailed off helplessly in the face of Jasi’s resignation. They’d tossed out every class they could think of, but none had seemed right for Jasi. But there were plenty of ‘possible’ options and ‘okay’ options. But nothing felt *right*.

In truth, it was Erin who was truly dissatisfied with Jasi and Grev’s opportunities. [Seamstress]? [Barber]? [Cook]? [Blacksmith]? All these jobs sounded…boring. Erin knew they were all important jobs that someone had to do, but if she had a choice, those would be far from her first ones.

At least [Runner] sounded marginally interesting. But—hadn’t Ryoka told Erin how much it sucked to be a Street Runner? And Erin was sure the other girl had complained at length about running countless miles to deliver some useless item for only a few silver coins. Unless you were a Courier, being a Runner sounded sort of boring too.

There it was again. Boring. Erin kept thinking the word. She sighed loudly again.

“I just don’t—I know we could find you a decent job, Jasi. But that’s not what you should want, y’know?”

Jasi exchanged a glance with Wesle.

“I don’t know, Miss Erin. What do you mean?”

Erin didn’t really know herself. She tried to explain as she slumped lower in her seat.

“It’s just...we’re talking about your future here. And you’re happy to get an okay job, I get that. But—don’t you want to be rich or famous? Don’t you have anything you want to do, anything special?”

She looked hopefully at Jasi, but just got a confused shake of the head in return.

“All I’ve ever wanted was to keep myself fed and clothed, Miss Erin. That’s all.”

The Drake had no idea how depressed that made Erin. How could she *not* want to do something special? But Jasi had been poor. Her dreams were real and urgent.

“You never wanted to be famous? Or live an exciting life?”

When she’d been younger, Erin had dreamed of being an astronaut. Then, when she’d been slightly older she’d wanted to be a legendary chess player, someone who could beat even a computer in chess. And then...she’d wanted to be a chess commentator, someone with a huge following or even a YouTube channel. Her dreams weren’t huge, true—most people didn’t even know chess commentary was an actual job. But they were big to Erin.

Jasi didn’t even have her own hopes and dreams. Erin looked at Grev.

“Don’t you want to be someone special?”

“Me?”

The young boy looked confused and slightly scared as Erin pointed at him. She nodded.

“Yeah, you. If you could have any class—do anything—what would you do?”

“I’d—I’d be a famous adventurer! A Gold-rank—no, a Named Adventurer! And I’d have a flaming sword and slay Dragons.”

Grev’s face immediately lit up, but Jasi only shook her head, looking upset.

“Please, Miss Erin. Don’t encourage Grev.”

“Why not?”

Erin glared at Jasi, making the Drake shrink back.

“Dreams are good! Important! If you could do anything, what would you do, Jasi?”

The Drake hesitated, and bit at her lip. Reluctantly, she replied.

“I suppose if I could I’d like to learn a craft and start a small business for myself—but even that’s a far-off dream, Miss Erin.”

She didn't quite deserve the dead gaze Erin gave her. Jasi just shrugged helplessly.

"It's all I can think of. If I could have anything—I guess I'd wish to be rich? Rich enough that I never have to work?"

"Really? That's boring too!"

Erin threw her hands up helplessly. Why were Jasi's ambitions so *small*? Why was she so upset? But it was just—

Boring. The same word again.

"Wesle!"

The man jumped.

"Yes, Erin?"

"What's your dream?"

He hesitated and turned slightly red. But the look in Erin's eyes didn't give him any wiggle room. Clearing his throat several times, Wesle blushing replied.

"I wanted to be an adventurer too. But—"

His hand fell back on his sword hilt helplessly. Wesle squeezed his eyes for a second.

"—But I'm afraid I can't be one. I'm not a born fighter like they are, Miss Erin. I can handle myself, but I'm not brave enough to go searching for evil to fight."

Wesle closed his eyes. He stared past Erin, at something in the distance. His voice softened, and his hand clenched around the mug on the table.

"If I could, I should have liked to have been a [Knight]. I would have loved to fight monsters and defend people by slaying creatures. And—yes, wielding a flaming sword. Or one that can cut through steel, at least."

His eyes refocused, and he coughed, turning beet-red. He looked afraid, as if he was sure the others in the room would laugh at him. But no one did.

Instead, his words made Jasi take a breath. She stared out the window, hesitating, and then spoke.

"If I could? If I had nothing to worry about? Maybe, maybe I'd travel to Liscor. To other cities. I'd like to know what Drakes—my people are like. I'd like to see what lies beyond Celum's walls."

She'd never left the city? But there were people like that too. Even back home, Erin remembered people, old people, who'd never even left their home state. They'd never flown on a plane or bothered to drive more than a hundred miles from where they were born and would die. She'd never

understood that, but then, Erin had travelled to other continents to play chess in tournaments when she was young.

Some days, it felt like Erin really was in a different world. Only, she was walking among aliens that wore human faces. She met people with small dreams, who were as small as insects. Sometimes. But then Erin looked deep into their souls and saw something familiar. Something she'd seen in a mirror when she was young.

Hope. Dreams.

Passion.

The man and Drake sitting at her table were very different, but they had the same look in their eyes. It wasn't what Erin saw in Agnes' pitying gaze, or Safry's shrug. There was still something in Wesle's expression, and Jasi's eyes when she stared at the window. They had a spark there, of something real and *alive*. But it was fading, and Erin saw it flickering in Jasi's resigned smile and the way Wesle shook his head when he talked about his past dreams.

They had hopes. They had ambitions. But it was buried so deep that they'd nearly forgotten about them. Erin touched her aching chest. And yet, what could you do? Octavia's words echoed in her mind. If you weren't willing to risk everything, what could you do?

Being an adventurer was a calling for the few, the insane and the brave and the desperate. But what else could people do if they didn't want to work their entire lives? Octavia was right. There was no other way to live. Either you took a risk and died or became famous or—you worked hard and kept your head down.

"It's not right."

That was all Erin said. She sat at the table and clenched her hands. This wasn't right. This was how the world was—how this world was. And she knew it was probably how the world had been, back in her world for thousands of years. But—

It wasn't right. There was more to life. She knew that. She lived, she had lived in a world where anyone could be anything. That was what she'd been taught as a child. And maybe it wasn't totally true, but it was that idea which people associated with her home country, with being an American. It was about equality, but it was also about hope.

Hope, and the faith that you could realize your dreams.

"Miss Erin?"

Erin looked up. Jasi and Wesle were looking at her. So was Grev.

“What?”

“You’ve been very quiet. Are you alright?”

“I am. It’s just—your world—your city—sort of sucks, guys.”

To Erin’s surprise, both Jasi and Wesle immediately frowned at her comment.

“I don’t know if that’s true.”

“Yeah. Celum isn’t perfect but—it’s just as good as Liscor.”

“Respectfully, Miss Erin, Celum is quite a good city to live in.”

Erin blinked at the force of their replies. Even Jasi was defending Celum. Why? Wesle’s normally amiable face looked quite upset as he stared challengingly at Erin.

“What makes you feel your home is that much better than Celum?”

“Where I come from—in the place where I used to be, people didn’t have so—so few options.”

Erin tried to explain to the indignant guardsman and Drake.

“We have plenty of options!”

“Indeed. Anyone can make something of themselves in Celum.”

“No—no, you guys don’t get it! Here you can only have boring jobs. Or—or be an adventurer and maybe die. But back home, people could be someone. They could be stars, celebrities!”

“Celebrities?”

The word was completely foreign to the two. Erin nodded energetically, suddenly able to put words to the sense of absence she’d been feeling recently.

“Yeah! Back home—even a girl or guy from a far off village could go to the big city and make their dreams come true. It was hard and risky, but they could take a chance. They could try and fulfill their dreams! If you wanted to, you could go there.”

“Where?”

The word came out of Erin’s childhood.

“Hollywood.”

The word burned in the silence. And suddenly, Erin remembered. She remembered movies and dreams and childhood. Yes, how could she have forgotten? But Wesle and Jasi didn’t get it. They just looked confused.

“What’s that? Some kind of tree?”

How could you explain Hollywood to people who hadn't even seen a movie? Erin grabbed at words and failed to find anything that would help. Hollywood was—it was movies! It was the silver screen, the place where hopes and stories became reality. Now things were different of course—there was Youtube and the internet. And you heard all kinds of bad things about Hollywood. Sexism, racism, jerkism...

But when Erin had been small, Hollywood had been the place where magic was made in her world. It had been the place where movies came from, a wondrous, far-off land. But how to describe it?

“*Broadway!* Plays! That’s what it’s like!”

Wesle’s chair scooted back as Erin suddenly shouted. Yes, that was it! She turned excitedly to the scared Drake and human.

“Haven’t you seen a play before? Hollywood is like a play except—better!”

Erin stared hopefully at the other two. They had to have seen a play before. That was—even in this world, they’d be common, right? Right? But her jaw dropped as the two shook their heads slowly.

“I’m afraid I’ve never seen one, Miss Solstice.”

“Neither have I.”

“*What?*”

The bug-eyed stare Erin was giving them made Jasi and Wesle feel uncomfortable. The guardsman cleared his throat nervously.

“If you mean a tumbling routine—I always catch those every time a festival happens. And of course I like to listen to stories in taverns if there’s a [Storyteller] travelling by.”

“I like to read books. We had one when I was young. It was worn, but —”

“*No!*”

Erin put her hands underneath the table and *flipped* it. It was the only thing that she could do, the only thing that could give vent to her emotions. The mugs, the drinks, plates and silverware all went flying. Jasi screamed and Wesle cried out in shock. As pottery crashed and broke on the floor, there was silence.

And standing, trembling, pointing at them, Erin. She stood on her chair, practically vibrating with passion.

“No! That isn’t a play! Plays are more than stupid tumbling, more than just a book! They’re full of—of romance! Drama! Love! Action! Intrigue

and betrayal and hope and—”

Erin waved her hands around wildly while Jasi, Wesle, and Grev all stared at her. Grev was already edging towards the stairs.

“You’re telling me none of you have *ever* seen a play before?”

“The table—”

Jasi squeaked as Erin rounded on her.

“No—no I haven’t!”

“Never? Why not?”

“There aren’t many people with that sort of class, Miss Erin! I mean, who would take a class like that on a whim? There are [Bards], Miss Erin. And—oh, maybe in large cities there are performances like that, but it’s not a job anyone can just learn.”

“What’s a play?”

Erin looked incredulously at Grev. But the boy had piped up, staring at Erin with curious eyes.

“You don’t know? It’s—it’s people telling a story. They pretend to be characters and they act out something funny or tragic. It’s like a book, but in real life!”

“Huh. Watch people pretend to be people in a story?”

Grev’s little nose wrinkled in disgust.

“Who’d want to see that?”

He flinched when Erin stared at him with wrath in her eyes. Wesle carefully raised a hand.

“I saw a performance like that once.”

“Really?”

He nodded, eyeing the broken plates and spilled drink on the ground.

“It was a wandering group of performers. They were telling everyone how a group of Gold-rank adventurers slew an entire nest of Griffins that had been preying on a town. It was a reenactment, and they had a fake Griffin creature they burned—”

“That’s not it either!”

Erin jumped off the chair and kicked it. She hopped around shouting in agony as Grev hid under the table. Jasi was petrified and Wesle had a hand on his sword as if he feared he’d have to defend himself.

“That’s not it at all!”

When Erin had calmed down a bit, she tried again. She couldn’t believe they didn’t know. She had to tell them. The knowledge was burning a hole

in her chest, trying to get out.

“Plays are—more than just reenactments, Wesle. They’re a story, a moment. If they’re boring they’re good—they should make you laugh and cry and *believe* what you’re seeing is real. Some of the most famous characters in history came from plays!”

“Like who?”

Erin didn’t have to think.

“Romeo and Juliet.”

“Who? I mean, what did they do?”

Jasi stared at Erin. Erin stared back. And then the girl leapt onto a table.

“*O Romeo, Romeo, wherefore art thou Romeo?* Who doesn’t know of the star-crossed lovers? Romeo of House Montague and Juliet of House Capulet! They, the two forbidden scions of each house dare the wrath of their families to find romance. Even if it means death, they would be together. At any cost.”

Jasi’s sharp teeth glinted as she gaped up at Erin. Wesle’s lips were parted in surprise. Erin bowed to them, flourishing on the table as if she were on stage.

“Two households, both alike in dignity,
In fair Verona, where we lay our scene,
From ancient grudge break to new mutiny,
Where civil blood makes civil hands unclean.”

She stared down at the staring faces, full of anger and emotion.

“*That* is the story of Romeo and Juliet.”

Only slack faces greeted Erin. She blinked, realized what had happened.

“Whoa. Did I do that?”

How *did* she do that? As Erin helped right the table and clean up the mess—the others were too shaken to do more than sit—she wondered what had happened.

She was no actor. Erin wasn’t even that good at acting. But in that moment, she’d perfectly recalled the opening lines of *Romeo and Juliet*, word for word! How? She didn’t have a perfect memory—she’d never even read the play! She’d just seen it performed once!

But wait a minute. Erin frowned as she mopped up the spilled drink and got rid of the broken pottery in a few seconds of brisk cleaning. She had Skills, didn't she? Not just [Advanced Cleaning].

She was a Level 6 [Singer]. And she had that skill—[Perfect Recall]. It didn't actually let Erin remember everything, it only worked for songs. Songs...and plays as it turned out. Yes, now that Erin concentrated, she found it was true! She could remember plays, entire passages out of books—anything that Erin considered artistic, really.

"I've never heard anything like it."

That was what Wesle kept repeating when Erin was done with cleaning up her accident. He sat at a table, staring at Erin.

"What strange way of speaking was that? It sounded grand and yet—it rhymed. I've never heard anything like it."

Erin sat at another table, trying to explain. Now she had all the attention of the room on her—not just attention, but fierce interest. It was like the crepes, like the new music all over again. Erin felt it. Here was something new, and it captivated the people of this world.

"That's a play. Some of them rhyme. It's called iambic pentameter."

"And what's that? Iambic...? Is it a Skill?"

"No, it's a way of speaking. Anyone can do it. It's—well, it's just a style. But it sounds good, doesn't it?"

"It does."

Both Jasi and Wesle nodded in agreement. Erin smiled.

"That's a play. Actually, that's not even it. What I just said, I'd say to the crowd before the actual play started. To understand a real play—you'd have to see it done with multiple actors on stage."

"I wish I could see that. It sounds—interesting."

Erin wished she could see that too. To see a movie, or a play—even one of the classics from her world like *The Wizard of Oz* would be...

Impossible. She sighed. But then Erin sat up. She stared at the female Drake sitting in front of her, eyes alight with interest, and the human male sitting next to her, fuzzy lipped and full of life.

And Erin had an obvious idea. She smiled widely, and looked at the two while Grev peeked at her from the kitchen.

"Well, why not? Would you two like to put on a play by yourselves?"

"Us?"

The two exchanged a glance. But Erin knew that they would say ‘yes’ before they even nodded.

It was a play. A new thing for this world, or maybe an ordinary thing made new. It was supposed to be grand and special. But—as Erin sat at her table, she realized that recreating a play wasn’t exactly the same as making crepes or playing a song on an iPhone.

What did she have? She had a perfect recall of the play Romeo and Juliet. That was a plus. And she had three willing people who wanted to experience a play. Another big plus. And they even had a place to practice. All of this should theoretically translate into a play.

But they’d hit upon a problem. And it was a rather big one. Wesle sighed as he pointed his sword at Grev from the center of the room. Grev held the scabbard in his hands, pretending it was a sword of his own. Both looked awkward, and were visibly hesitating.

“Don’t hesitate! Just say your lines!”

Erin called out to them from her director’s seat. She’d pushed back all the tables to the walls to give them room to perform in, and she was sitting with Jasi at a table. But the two actors still looked uncomfortable.

“I don’t know if I understand how it should go.”

“I explained it to you. Just give it a shot!”

Erin called out encouragingly to Wesle as he hesitated. He frowned, nodding and mouthing his lines silently. Grev held his scabbard up, doing the same thing.

They were reenacting a fight scene between Romeo and Paris, because Grev had wanted to try acting as well. Of course, Paris wasn’t supposed to be a little boy, but it was as close as Erin could do. And it was a dramatic scene! They were fighting right before Paris was slain and Romeo killed himself. It should have been a powerful moment that needed no direction.

But—

But Erin had begun to realize the error in using Romeo and Juliet as her introduction to plays. It hadn’t seemed like a mistake before, but it was becoming more and more obvious to her as time wore on.

At first glance, Shakespeare made sense. He was a famous guy—his works were classic! And yet—Erin had to admit, the language the famous

Bard of Avalon used was...difficult at best.

“Go for it, Grev!”

“Okay!”

The boy spoke awkwardly, trying to force the lines of iambic pentameter into natural cadence.

“Condemned villain, I do apprehend thee:

Obey, and go with me; for thou must die.”

He pointed his scabbard at Wesle. The man took a step back and took a deep breath. Wesle cleared his throat and began reciting Romeo’s lines.

“I must indeed, and therefore came I hither.

Good gentle youth, tempt not a desperate man.

Fly hence and leave me. Think upon these gone.

Let them affright thee. I beseech thee, youth—I say, isn’t this rather long?”

Erin groaned and beside her, Jasi covered her face.

“Even if it’s long, say the lines! You’re supposed to!”

“I’m afraid I can’t remember them all!”

Grev sighed and lowered his tired arm as Wesle walked over to consult with Erin. She sighed too. This wasn’t working.

Romeo and Juliet. A timeless play, or so the critics said. Except that time was dragging on here and everyone was clearly growing more and more tired of the play as they fumbled on.

Erin blamed Shakespeare, or more accurately, his dialogue. It was impressive, yes. A woven script filled with a craftsman’s trickery with words. Even more impressive, it was in iambic pentameter, making each meter and verse doubly significant.

And that was the problem. It was *dense*. Now that Erin was recalling the full script, she realized how complex it was! Soliloquies, monologues, clever asides and tricks of dialogue...not to mention all the side characters!

For an audience who liked wit and humor, for an audience of Shakespeare’s time, it was great stuff, Erin had no doubt. But it wasn’t a story that captivated her heart—or her reluctant actor’s.

“Try again. You’re supposed to be enraged, in the middle of passion!”

“I can barely remember what to say.”

Wesle groaned. He tried again.

“Good gentle youth, tempt not a desperate man!”

Erin shook her head.

“No, no. It’s too awkward. You sound like you’re just reciting the words, not *acting*.”

“Well—”

Wesle threw up his hands, out of words. He stalked over to Grev and snatched his scabbard back. Erin ruffled her hair.

“Argh. Maybe—let’s try a Romeo and Juliet scene. I went over the play with you guys—you *know* how important their meeting on the balcony is. Let’s do that.”

Jasi nodded and stood up. Reluctantly, Wesle walked over to the other side of the room, and bowed his head.

He wasn’t liking this. That made Erin concerned. She went over to him.

“Hey. Are you not enjoying it?”

“I—don’t know, Miss Solstice. I don’t.”

Wesle just shrugged, looking both annoyed and disheartened.

“When you spoke the lines of the play I got chills, I truly did. But trying to make it into an actual play, to act it out—it’s a different thing entirely.”

Erin nodded. Her audience had listened to her go quickly through the entire play of Romeo and Juliet, drinking in the story like sponges. They’d even memorized entire lines of the play by rote—something Erin had thought was impossible! Apparently when you didn’t have a computer or iPhone handy, your ability to remember things you’d heard was a lot better.

They’d liked the play. But they didn’t like acting. Or rather, Wesle didn’t. Grev liked the mock swordfight and he’d hit Wesle several times with the scabbard, and Jasi had liked playing Juliet. But it was just play-acting, not the real thing.

Erin thought Wesle was trying for the real thing, but he couldn’t figure it out. She’d tried to show him, but acting wasn’t something he’d ever witnessed. All she could give him was her advice, and she had very little of that.

“Just do your best.”

“I *am*.”

Wesle clenched his fists as Jasi murmured her lines and practiced looking elegant. She really did seem to love the idea of the role.

“What’s wrong? Is it that you can’t figure out how to move?”

“No, it’s—I know it sounds silly, Erin, but I’m just not Romeo. I can’t be this grand hero in love. I’m just—Wesle. Just a [Guardsmen], not a young [Lord].”

Wesle’s shoulders slumped. Erin looked at him, and understood a bit. She touched his shoulder and pulled him around.

“I know you’re not Romeo. But no one’s Romeo when they play him, Wesle. They become him.”

He looked at her, frustrated, helpless.

“*How?*”

Erin hesitated. She looked at Jasi, who was watching her anxiously, and at Grev. How could she explain acting to people who lived such small lives? Who didn’t have dreams? Who were beaten down by this stupid world and system they lived under?

Well...how else? Erin suddenly knew what to say. She looked back at Wesle, looked him right in the eyes.

“Haven’t you ever—*ever* wanted to be someone else? To be someone you’re not?”

Wesle hesitated, opened his mouth. Closed it. Grimaced.

“Of course.”

“Then that’s what you do. You don’t want to be someone else. For a little while, but a few moments—you *become* them. This is you, on stage, living out your dream.”

She pointed at Jasi, pointed at the stage, the empty bit of ground they’d cleared.

“This is your one chance. Forget about me, forget about the people watching you—you’re Romeo right now, a young nobleman who only has eyes for Juliet. You’re not Wesle. Wesle has a fuzzy mustache and he’s just a [Guardsmen]. You’re Romeo. And you’re in love.”

Wesle stared at Erin, and she wondered if she’d failed. But then without a word he walked towards Jasi. The Drake was ready, and she called out even as Wesle strode towards her, back straight.

“What man art thou that thus bescreen’d in night so stumblest on my counsel?”

Wesle walked towards Jasi, and then knelt before her. Erin had thought that was appropriate for Romeo. He looked only a bit awkward as he stared up at Jasi imploringly. Still fake. But he was trying.

“By a name I know not how to tell thee who I am—”

Wesle stumbled over his words and bit his tongue. Erin winced. The language was just too hard! She was about to jump in, to tell him it was alright, when she saw something change.

The [Guardsmen] kneeling in front of Jasi as the Drake tried to pretend she had a dress suddenly paused. He stopped, hesitated as he thought of his next lines, and then tossed away the script he had memorized. He rose, and took Jasi's hand in his own. Startled, the Drake looked at him, but Wesle's face was serious, his eyes intent on hers.

"My name, my very nature, dear [Lady], I hate myself—because it is an enemy to you. Had I my name and race written down, I would tear up like parchment."

That wasn't what Romeo was supposed to say! And yet—it was exactly what he was supposed to say! Erin held her breath, delighted, as Jasi paused. She was thinking too, and suddenly there was a glint in her eyes. She pulled her hand free, staring haughtily at Wesle.

"You've not spoken a hundred words, but I already know that you are no Drake. Art thou not Romeo, a *Human*?"

He looked ashamed, and retreated a step before he bowed his head.

"I would be neither of those things, fair [Lady], if you dislike them. For you—I would be anything."

Suddenly, he advanced on her, trying to put an arm around her waist. Jasi pulled back, but then stepped forwards. She grabbed Wesle's shirt, and he yelped a bit in surprise.

Romeo and Juliet stood together, youthful, full of passion. Juliet, tail thrashing the ground, pulled Romeo closer to her, her eyes alight with passion.

"Tempt not a desperate Drake, Human."

Erin covered her mouth, whispering the words to herself in shocked glee.

"*That's* not in the script!"

But this was more than the script. Erin watched Wesle pull back, full of—of condescending hauteur, but also deep interest. They exchanged more lines, and then Romeo knelt, catching at Juliet's hand again.

"I fear your hand is too noble for mine to ever touch. But I have two blushing balms to offer you, my lips—to smooth your rough scales with a tender kiss."

Juliet laughed, pulling back and mocking him with her own words.

“I feel you do your hands too much discredit, sir. For after all, balms touch even [Queens] and [Ladies] – and if two hands should touch, well that too is like a kiss.”

Filled with consternation, Romeo stood up again, gesturing helplessly at Juliet’s face.

“Do not [Queens] and [Ladies] have lips to kiss with?”

“Of course they do. But balm is not meant for lips.”

She laughed at him, but Romeo was too caught up. He approached, and caught hold of her shoulders, speaking urgently.

“Then let us have lips do what hands do! Please, grant me this—answer my request, or let my hope become despair.”

Even as close as they were, Juliet found the wherewithal to turn her head away and up. Her tail twined about a chair leg, gripping it tightly.

“I’m afraid [Ladies] have no hopes to give. Only laws to make.”

“Then do not move as I act out my hope—”

The audience’s jaws dropped as Romeo kissed Juliet once in passion. He whispered the words as she stared at him in shock and something more.

“Now then, the crime of my assaulting a [Lady] rests on your lips, not mine.”

She smiled, tremulously, still holding on to a [Lady]’s dignity even in this moment.

“Oh? My lips bear your crimes now, do they?”

Romeo’s voice was rough.

“Your lips would turn an honest man to crime with their sweetness. Give me my crime back.”

They kissed again. Only this time, Juliet met Romeo halfway. It was a passionate kiss—and frankly, one that Erin thought Grev should not be watching.

On stage, Erin watched as Wesle and Jasi locked lips, and then continued the scene, slightly breathless but still in character. She had no idea if this was an act or if they’d be jumping each other soon.

No—this was part of the act. They were lost in the characters. And even as Erin watched, Romeo and Juliet came to life before her eyes, not Capulet and Montague, but Human and Drake, caught in forbidden interspecies love.

Erin held her breath as the two continued to act. Her eyes were locked on the performance, trying to capture every second of it before it slipped

away. This wasn't an [Immortal Moment]. Time didn't stop here; because this wasn't her scene. She was only part of the audience, a witness to the drama.

How could people act like this so naturally? Maybe it was because they had nothing to cling to. There was no ego in the way they held each other, only two lost lovers daring fate to be together.

The two who stood on the small stage in the inn were playing out roles bigger than themselves. For a little while, they were not Wesle the low-level [Guardsmen] and Jasi the impoverished Drake working as a [Washer]. They were Romeo and Juliet, and their story was legend.

So Erin sat and watched the play continue. Grev jumped in, all faulty lines and overenthusiastic acting, and she had to fill in multiple roles herself. It was far from a good play, but for those living each scene, it was special in itself. It was new. It was unique. It was...

A bit of culture. A timeless story, travelling from one world to the other. It wasn't perfect—it wasn't accurate to the script and it certainly wasn't in iambic pentameter. But the spirit was there. It was in every line of dialogue, delivered with clumsy passion and all of each actor's heart.

It was the stage. And it had come to Celum.

Several hours later, Erin realized the play had to be performed. Even after Wesle and Jasi had collapsed tiredly into the chairs—that was just the start.

They needed actors, a set, and audience! When Erin suggested a live performance both man and Drake froze, but they said yes. She had a feeling they would have said yes even if it meant playing all the parts themselves.

But they wouldn't be alone. Erin was sure of that. Grev had applauded the play—Grev, the boy who could barely sit in one place for long. And the story was compelling; it was a story *for* this world, especially given the real and pressing animosity between Drakes and Humans.

And it would be told. Erin was certain of that. She would make it happen.

The first thing they needed was a place to practice. And happily, they had the inn. They just needed to make sure they wouldn't be interrupted,

namely by Miss Agnes, who had come back full of affronted pride to help manage the lunch crowd.

“Lunch? Who has time for lunch!?”

Erin closed the door in Agnes’ face, only opening it again when the woman hammered on the door.

“You can’t just close the inn! Think of all the coin we’d lose!”

“Too bad! Today the inn’s closed! You said you had things to do, right? Well—do them!”

“How dare you! This is my inn and I—”

Erin opened the door and grabbed Miss Agnes’ hand. She pulled Agnes nose-to-nose with her. The woman stared into Erin’s intense, almost magic gaze.

“Get lost! We’re making *art* here!”

She ran. Erin had no time for her. She was too busy coordinating the play with the others.

“Who would want to act? We need male actors and female ones. And costumes! And a set! I mean, we can do without, but it looks better that way.”

“There aren’t any Drakes in the city, are there? We’d need some to play the Capulets...”

“No wait—there is one! The [Baker], Mister Hess who lives on Springbottom street! I could see him—explain—”

“What about other actors?”

Wesle was stroking his mustache furiously, on an adrenaline high from the performance.

“I’ll go to the Watch House. I’m sure there are plenty of men and women who’d love to try this. But how can I explain it to them?”

“Go together!”

Erin was practically bouncing with excitement. She’d grabbed her bag of coins and she was excitedly pushing gold ones into Grev’s hands.

“You two can do a scene from the play for them. And tell people we’ll perform it here! Tonight! Admission is free, and they can buy food and drink!”

She gave up on counting coins and dumped a handful of them into Grev’s hands. The young boy stared at the glittering pile, poleaxed.

“I want costumes, Grev! Clothing for rich people, [Lords] and [Ladies]! And swords!”

“I think I can borrow weapons from the Watch House.”

“Okay, no swords! But get me clothing! And curtains! I want big, red ones! Doesn’t matter if you have to get them to sew it together—it’s going to hang up there and we’ll pull them aside for each scene!”

“What about ah, what did you call them? Props?”

“*Props!*”

Erin pulled Grev back as he eagerly ran for the door.

“Get me...yeah, get a [Carpenter] and a [Painter] to make some backgrounds! No, wait, I’ll do it! They can draw a city, and a garden and —!”

The girl ran out of the inn. Grev led her to a [Painter]’s store—a man who decorated houses and created art for the nobility. She kicked down the door when he refused to open it. He screamed for the Watch, but they were all busy. Busy auditioning for a play.

And when Erin dragged the poor man to meet the best [Carpenter] in town, news was spreading. How could it not? Here was something interesting, and people were talking about it in the streets. Not too many people of course—word could only spread so fast by word of mouth, and Celum was a big city. There was always something happening.

And yet, the word ‘play’ had a magic of its own. It spread from person to person, from the Watch House to the bakery where the [Baker] suddenly took a day off for some strange reason. It attracted attention—especially when they saw that new, young [Innkeeper] ran into Stitchworks, and dragged the [Alchemist] out, kicking and screaming.

Something was clearly happening. People began asking questions. What was a play? Was it like a street performance? No? Then what was it? How did it go? Would it cost anything? When was it happening?

What would it be like?

That night, a crowd of people gathered in the Frenzied Hare. It wasn’t a huge amount of people—at least, not in terms of the city’s full population. But it packed two thirds of the room until there was only a little bit of space for the two put-upon [Barmaids] and one [Innkeeper] to circulate the room, passing out drinks and food.

Behind the red curtain that had been hastily stitched together, Erin ran over the play with her actors. They were all new, and they'd barely had time to practice more than once or twice. For any other director, this might have been their worst nightmare.

But to Erin, it was just a lovely dream. The people in front of her might still be memorizing their lines, but they had more passion in their toenails than she'd seen from some actors on stage. She gave them what tips she could, and trusted them to do the rest. Even someone who hadn't acted in more than one or two school plays like Erin could pass along some important advice.

"Always be looking at the audience. Even if you're facing one another—do it so the audience can see your entire body. Like this."

She demonstrated, and the gathered cast watched her nervously. Some asked questions, others shook with stage fright. The [Baker] passed out, but by the time the curtains drew back, he was ready to go, if vibrating with fright.

The play began. Erin was in agony as she alternated between cooking—throwing together the most mass-producible meals she could of soups and breads, sending Maran running to buy more food to sell at outrageous prices to her guests—while hurrying back out to watch the magic.

"Two species, both alike in dignity,
In fair Celum, where we lay our scene,
From ancient grudge break to new mutiny,
Where civil blood makes civil hands unclean."

Grev stood in the center of the stage, declaiming to the audience. He was white with fright, but his words made the listeners murmur in interest. Erin bit at her fingernails with glee as the actors came out.

The story of Romeo and Juliet was simple. Complex, and simple. At the heart of it was a love affair. But in the first scenes, the play started with a brawl between the two families, or in this case, the two races. Drakes, or rather, people dressed as Drakes and one actual Drake drew real swords and dueled with angry Humans. Actual blood was spilled, but fortunately, not much.

Erin was too busy shoving hot bowls of soup at Miss Agnes—and spilling some on the woman—to see the fight. But she heard the shout as

the fighting ceased.

“Swords! Lay down your unlawful swords!”

The actors paused and reluctantly tossed their blades on the ground. A huge man—the actual Watch Captain of Celum himself strode onto the stage with actual [Guardsmen] at his back. He was practically bursting with outrage as he roared at the audience who flinched back from him.

“You men, you beasts! Rebellious subjects, enemies to peace! These brawls by old Capulet, and Montague have thrice disturb’d the quiet of our streets. If ever you disturb our homes again, your lives shall pay the forfeit of the peace! Go now! On pain of death, all men depart!”

The play continued as the lead actor, Romeo, played by Wesle, was introduced. He went to a ball at the house of a famous Drake [Lord] and there laid eyes on the lovely Juliet, played by Jasi for the first time.

Erin watched the audience’s expressions. She’d wondered whether they’d like a Drake and Human romance, but despite being from another world and never having seen a play before, they were Humans. Forbidden love captured their hearts and minds and they fell in love with Juliet the moment she took the stage. They sighed and cheered as Romeo and Juliet hit it off.

But then—from the love scene on the balcony, tragedy! Romeo’s friend Mercutio was slain on stage as the audience cried out in shock and horror. In a rage, Romeo confronted the Drake named Tybalt, sword in hand.

Wesle pointed a sword at the Drake’s, full of fury and rage.

“Turn hellhound, turn!”

Erin had liberally used other famous lines from Shakespeare’s plays to add to the drama. The Drake playing Tybalt sneered at Wesle, raising his own sword with a flourish. Undeterred, Romeo advanced, holding his sword with wrath and rage.

“Damn mercy and peace. Fire-eyed fury be my conduct now! Mercutio’s body is not yet cold—waiting for you or I to give it company in the grave!”

“You fool.”

Tybalt sneered at Romeo, lifting his own sword with a dismissive flick of the tail.

“You are no [Duelist], and my own levels number over twenty one. Thou, wretched boy, that didst consort him here shalt with him hence.”

Adapted for this world, and mixed with the language of the Bard himself. Erin watched at the two dueled, and then saw how Juliet found herself trapped in a marriage against her will, while she yearned to be with her true love, Romeo. Her only option was to pretend to die so she could join Romeo in exile.

Thus, Jasi as Juliet implored the dark-skinned girl holding glowing potions to brew her a potion to reunite her with her love. A plea, as it turned out, that Octavia playing Octavia was only too willing to grant.

The Stitch Girl dominated the stage, playing to her audience hard as she mixed harmless liquids together to create a spectacular reaction for the awed crowd. She held the completed glowing red liquid towards Juliet, chattering away.

“A potion to feign death isn’t hard to brew. But this is very costly. Fortunately for you, Octavia’s Stitchworks offers substantial discounts to all customers, and my new line of potions which I’ve marked down nearly 50%—”

“Give me the potion, you heartless [Alchemist]!”

Juliet snatched the bottle away from Octavia, cutting the surprise monologue short. Octavia sniffed, affronted.

“Well excuse *me* for trying to do business.”

That got a laugh, and then the story continued. At the end, Juliet wept over Romeo’s corpse, too slow, and too late to prevent her love from dying.

As the sounds of her pursuers reached her ears, Juliet stood in despair, holding the dagger in her hands. Erin heard people in the audience shouting at her not to do anything, but it was too late. Oblivious to the crowd, Juliet stared down at the pointed blade.

“Yea, noise? Then I’ll be brief. O happy dagger,
This is thy sheath. There rust and let me die.”

The dagger plunged into her chest, and the red potion Octavia had made spurted forwards. The crowd was on their feet, but the play continued before they could rush the stage.

In the end, after all the lamentation was done, the Watch Captain stood in front of the audience, head bowed, standing in front of the grieving parents of the slain lovers. He spoke to the crowd, his deep voice and sorrowful eyes finding each person in the crowd.

“A glooming peace this morning with it brings;
The sun, for sorrow, will not show his head:
Go hence, to have more talk of these sad things;
Some shall be pardon’d, and some punished:
For never was a story of more woe
Than this of Juliet and her Romeo.”

And after that—there was nothing. Erin had never seen a speechless crowd, but when they regained their voices there was only sound and cheering. The cast had to come out to bow, had to shake hands and even perform some scenes over again, such was the enthusiasm in the room.

Erin missed all of it. Halfway through the play the audience had forgotten to eat, so spellbound they’d been. But with the thrilling conclusion their hunger came back in force. She cooked like there was no tomorrow, even though it was tomorrow by the time she was done.

And when it was over? When the last actor staggered out of the inn and Erin had hugged Jasi and watched Agnes collapse onto a table, the bag of coins she’d earned held blissfully on her chest. When she’d seen Wesle walk away, his step full of confidence and—and hope?

She went back up to her room, walking slowly. Erin’s head was full of cotton; her arms and legs were lead. She lay back in her bed, too tired to undress or clean her teeth. The curtain call was upon her, but she delayed the ending for one moment to stare up at the ceiling.

In the darkness, Erin smiled. She spoke to the night.
“Good. This isn’t boring at all.”

[Innkeeper Level 29!]

[Skill – Crowd Control Obtained!]

3.17 T

This is the story of a skeleton named Toren. He laid on his back, staring at the grey sky. He was a skeleton. This fact was readily apparent to him and anyone who saw him. He was a skeleton.

And he was free.

That was all Toren knew. All he understood, really. There had been a time when he was not free, and he had been forced to labor ceaselessly. He hadn't actually minded most of his duties, in point of fact. Hauling water, cleaning up spilled food and drink—that wasn't arduous for a skeleton. And Toren had even liked some of his duties which included bossing about a certain annoying Human girl.

But somehow, even the theoretically limitless patience of a skeleton had been stretched by some of his tasks. Like collecting honey while bees dropped him hundreds of feet out of the air to smash into the ground. Or having to pull—

Dingle.

Toren *twitched* once as he lay on the ground, but other than that he lay still. He had to be still. He kept thinking. Remembering, really.

Yes, he had been held captive by the orders. But then had come the glorious, wonderful moment when he'd found a way to escape them! He'd left his mistress—his owner—Erin Solstice behind in the snow where she would hopefully get lost forever or starve to death and thus freed himself.

He was free. If Toren had lips, he might have tried to smile. Since his face was a grinning skull he didn't have to bother. But that smile would have quickly faded away, again, if Toren had any flesh to move.

Yes, Toren was free. But so what? What did that mean? Toren had no idea. Now that he was free, what should he do? What was his purpose?

Ever since Toren had leveled up and become a [Skeleton Knight], all kinds of new thoughts had begun popping up in his head. Some were useful—like the idea to leave Erin behind so she couldn't order him about. But others just made him confused. He'd never had to wonder about his purpose before.

Toren was a skeleton. He had been made to fight—at least, to fight in order to protect. But Toren liked fighting. He liked leveling up, so he'd

gone out of his way to kill everything he could. And that was good, but was there something else he should be doing?

He didn't know. If Toren had lungs he might have sighed. But he didn't, so the purple flames in his eyes just flickered for a moment as they dimmed. What should he do next? He couldn't just lie here forever. Well, he could, but—

“What's this?”

Toren heard a voice and didn't move. He heard crunching footsteps as someone—two someones—walked towards him in the snow. Still, he didn't move.

“Dead gods. It looks like an attack! Someone's killed these two people!”

“A bandit raid? Are they still nearby, do you think?”

There was another voice. Toren really didn't care about the gender of the speakers—if pressed, he might have admitted one sounded male and the other sounded female. He just listened quietly as the two conferred.

“Might be—but look! They didn't even make off with the money pouch! Here—”

“What are you doing? You can't just take it!”

“Can't I? These poor saps aren't going to use it any time soon, and it's a lucky find for us. We'll report the bodies when we get to Celum; that'll repay the debt.”

“It's stealing!”

“From the dead? If they care so much, let them stop me.”

Because Toren had no sense of irony, it was only after the man had rummaged around a bit and collected the coin that he stood up. He casually brushed snow off of his bones and walked over to the man and woman engrossed by the two corpses.

“Hm?”

The man noticed something and turned around. He turned, saw Toren, and screamed.

“*Skele—*”

Toren beheaded the man with one slash and then turned to the woman. She screamed.

“*Hemlet!*”

Toren paused. Did she mean the man? He was missing his head. Unless he could fight without it like Toren could, the skeleton really doubted

yelling his name would do any good.

Still, wouldn't that be interesting? Toren stared at the corpse hopefully.

...Nope. It wasn't moving. After a few moments he noticed the woman was running. Toren ran after her.

A fun fact no one cared about was that skeletons were actually light enough to run on the top of the snow if it had a crust. Toren easily caught up to the woman and a few seconds later he was dragging her body next to the man's. The blood on his bones and the ground was the only splash of color in the lifeless landscape. That and his eyes, of course.

He had purple eyes. Or rather, purple flames burning in his eye sockets. Toren thought about that as he carefully buried the two bodies of his latest victims with the others. When he'd first been created, he'd had blue eyes. But after...absorbing a gemstone he'd taken from a certain monster named Skinner, he'd gained the power to inflict [Fear] on people. And his eyes had changed color.

Toren didn't mind that part. He would have gladly turned his eyes any color for the [Fear] effect. But it was interesting to him because the skeleton was by and large immortal and unchangeable in most respects.

He could regenerate. If his bones were separated, they came back together. And even if they were crushed or disintegrated—as they had been once by Corusdeer horns—they would eventually recreate themselves.

That meant that while Toren was very hard to destroy permanently, few things about his nature could be altered. And yet his eyes had changed.

The skeleton considered this detail as he washed the blood off of his bones with snow, rendering him yellow-white and practically invisible against the snowy background. He lay down again and kept thinking as he waited.

He could change. He could be something else. That mattered because... well, because he could level. That was an important thing to Toren. When he leveled, he thought more. And he grew stronger. Both of these things were good. And if he leveled up enough, then maybe one day Erin Solstice wouldn't be able to order him around at all.

That was a good thought. Toren liked that idea. He grinned as he lay in the snow, staring at the sky.

Someday. Someday he'd go back to that inn with a sword. And then he'd let Erin yell at him and boss him around. And then he'd—

Kill her. Right?

Toren paused, mid-grin. He hadn't really thought that far ahead. Would he kill Erin? It was the logical answer. But really, Toren only wanted to be free of the orders. He only considered Erin's death as it pertained to her ordering him about. But what if he could ignore the orders? Would he kill her then?

This was a serious question for the skeleton, and a distressing one! As he thought about it, he realized he didn't actually know if he would kill or not kill Erin. And that went for all the other people who visited her inn.

The fact that Toren *did not have* a would-kill list for every being in the world was very upsetting for the skeleton. He quickly made one up as he waited for someone else to notice the victims he'd killed days ago lying in the snow.

They were so handy. Toren had killed the first travelers on a small side road and he'd been about to go on his way when he realized they were perfect bait. He'd used them as distractions to ambush a score of other travelers as they passed by. Not for any real purpose; he was fairly sure that this didn't help him level up that much. It was just a way to pass the time as he thought deep thoughts.

It was fun.

Anyways. A kill list. If Toren had the ability to kill anyone—if he leveled up enough, in short—who would he kill? The idea intrigued him.

Well, who would he kill first? The bees, obviously. He'd slaughter their entire damn hive. And then after the bees he'd probably kill...Lyonette.

Yes. Toren's eyes burned in his sockets. He would enjoy that. She was so annoying, and she'd stopped him from going hunting so many times! Lyonette was second.

And after her, who would be next? Maybe the girl who Erin talked to often. Ryoka. It wasn't that the girl was more annoying than the other guests that Erin entertained—it was just that Toren didn't like her. More specifically, he didn't like her body. Her bone structure bothered him a bit. Maybe it was her shinbones. They were a tad too long, and Toren just disliked that.

Hm? Dislike? Had he just thought that?

Toren sat up in the snow and tapped at his head with one finger. Then he looked around and quickly lay back down.

Had he really thought that? But yes—now that Toren thought about it, he had things he disliked! That was an...odd thing. Before this moment,

Toren had never thought about liking and disliking things. But now he knew there were things in this world he hated.

Like Ryoka's shin bones. And Lyonette. And the bees! And anything that went *dingle*.

Yes, the bells. Toren added the bells and the sleigh onto his kill list. He'd destroy them too. They might not be alive, but he'd find a way. Maybe he'd melt the bells. And set the sleigh on fire. That felt appropriate to him.

Toren was enjoying coming up with his kill list. But he paused as another thought hit him, bouncing through his empty cranium and finding whatever part of him was actually doing the thinking.

If he had something he hated, what did he actually like?

It was an odd question. But Toren understood the word 'dislike', even if he didn't think of it in actual words. But the idea of 'dislike' was that there was an opposite, right? If Toren had something he hated, he had to have something he loved.

That was a rule. If there was no love, there could be no hatred. If there was no positive to balance out the negative, the world was simply a void of one thing. So Toren *had* to have a like or his hatred made no sense.

Right? Toren tried to frown, but the closest he could do was tap his knucklebones against his skull a few times. This was a conundrum. Didn't he have anything he liked doing?

Well—killing things. And leveling up. But was there anything else? Surely there was. Toren thought hard, abandoning his hiding spot to stand up and pace about in his intense concentration.

And then heard a sound. It didn't come from the world around him. Rather, it echoed in his mind. It came up from some hidden place in him. A sound. No—not a sound. A voice.

Music.

Once upon a time, the skeleton had heard music. He had stood in an inn, watching a girl sing. He had never known music existed until that moment. And he had heard the words, and they had burned themselves into his soul.

Music.

Toren's fist rose. He *punched* himself in the head as hard as he could, but it was too late. The music was in his head again. He immediately hit himself in the head with his sword to make it go away.

But the music still remained. It wasn't a sound he could run from, and he couldn't forget it.

It haunted him. The skeleton had no brain that could decay, no memories that could fade and tarnish with emotion and age. For him, every time he heard the song he was caught in the same moment, listening with wonder and awe.

It was too much. Too much to bear. Toren dropped his sword and *threw* himself onto the ground. He thrashed about, sending snow flying, getting up, throwing himself on hard dirt again. Trying to hurt himself. Trying to make the music go away. He didn't even notice the armed people staring at him until one of them cast a spell.

The adventuring team stared at the skeleton flopping around in the snow like a fish in silence for a few minutes.

“Is it some kind of rare undead, do you think?”

One of the adventurers, a [Fighter] holding a sword in his hands—whispered to his two companions. They just shrugged, staring at that thrashing skeleton in confusion.

“I don't know. Maybe something went wrong with it?”

“Looks like it. But it's probably the monster that's been causing all these disappearances over the last few days.”

“Should we kill it? Or—maybe capturing it would be better? Would the Guild give us a bounty for that?”

The adventurers stared at the skeleton. He was throwing himself around like a dying fish, banging his head against the ground, rolling about in a ball...

Eventually, the mage in the three-man team cast a spell.

“[Pebbleshot]!”

It wasn't a high-Tier spell, but the bits of stone the female [Mage] levitated up and hurled at the skeleton had quite a lot of force behind them. One *cracked* into the skeleton's skull and fractured the bone on his forehead. The skeleton lay on the ground, seemingly stunned, and then got up. He stared at the Bronze-rank team silently. Then he grabbed the sword at his side and ran at them.

Another pebble smashed into his forehead. Toren stumbled back as more hit his arms, his body—

The spell wasn't really a good one to use on a skeleton. Over half of the stones the [Mage] sent smacking into him just passed through his body or bounced off without doing any real damage. Still, it was annoying. Toren staggered as another one struck him directly in the center of his chest and then he overbalanced.

The three adventurers watched as the skeleton fell backwards, disappearing over a slight mound of snow. The two warriors—a young man and a woman, holding a sword and spear respectively—were ready in case the skeleton charged. But he didn't appear once he'd fallen.

"Do you think it can't get back up?"

"Could be. Let's advance—cautiously."

The three moved forwards a few steps, watching the spot where the skeleton had gone. They'd gone about six feet when an innocuous patch of snow next to them suddenly *shifted*.

Toren arced out of the snow like an angry bone-fish, slashing wildly as the adventurers screamed and tried to defend themselves. He cut at the mage as she screamed, managing to slice her deeply on one arm and down her shoulder across the chest before the [Fighter] thrust her out of the way. He slashed at Toren while his companion struck at the skeleton from the other side.

"Don't let it get away!"

One had a sword, the other a spear. Neither was particularly useful in damaging the skeleton, and Toren ignored the few light cuts he received while he tried to hack at the man with the sword.

But the adventurers, for all their poor choice of weaponry, were a team. While the [Fighter] blocked and dodged Toren's attacks, his friend struck Toren from the side and behind, hitting the skeleton with heavy strikes of her spear.

It was annoying. Toren stepped back as the [Fighter] counterattacked, bringing his sword down in a two-handed cut intended to smash Toren's skull. He leapt backwards, but a spear struck his spine and made him stumble forwards instead.

"Got you!"

The [Fighter]'s sword slashed out horizontally towards Toren's neck. But even as the sword touched the skeleton's neck, Toren's entire body *blurred*.

"Wh—"

The man's words cut off as Toren's own sword slashed at his arm, impossibly quick. The blade cut down to the bone and even into it—Toren wrenched away the sword as the [Fighter] screamed and his comrade shouted in confusion.

[Mirage Cut]. In satisfaction, Toren watched as the man cried out and clutched at his useless arm. One down. He turned to the spear-wielder—
“[Pebbleshot]!”

A stone the size of Toren's palm smacked him in the head. He rocked backwards on his feet and took a step back to steady himself.

New plan. Kill the [Mage] first. But when he raised his sword, he found that all three adventurers were...running?

“Get away!”

The woman with the spear had abandoned her weapon to help her friend run. The [Mage] was casting [Pebbleshot] at Toren, slowing him down as they ran back towards the main road.

Briefly, the skeleton considered giving chase. But in the end he just shook his head and lay back down in the snow. He was too busy thinking to bother chasing them, especially if it meant being hit by more pebbles.

However, the sudden burst of violence had cheered Toren up considerably. He'd completely forgotten about the music, and so he went back to his original line of thought.

Very well, if he had things he liked and disliked, then what about things he wanted to do? That was another intriguing question, and again, something Toren had never thought of. But now that he was free, what *should* he do?

Staying here to ambush passersby was losing a lot of its charm. Toren wanted...to be stronger. He wanted to level up freely, like he'd done when Erin hadn't needed him around her inn. Yes, that was it! Toren would level up. Only after he'd gotten strong—much stronger than he was now would he worry about his kill list.

And on that note...Toren remembered the adventurers who'd beaten him with ease, quite unlike the ones he'd just routed. Griffon Hunt. All of them—and especially the [Scout], the one who'd shot him through the head—were far more powerful than Toren was, he was sure of it.

Becoming as strong as them was a good goal, wasn't it? Toren stood up decisively. It was settled. He'd become stronger by killing things.

It had taken the skeleton many days to come to this conclusion. But the difference between Toren's line of thought before and now was clear. Before, he'd just killed to level up, and because he wanted to. Now, he wanted to kill to level up to be as strong as the Griffon Hunt team. There was a huge distinction between such pointless actions and his new goal.

But where should he do it? Toren hit upon his first problem almost immediately as he dug around in the snow. Killing people on the road was all very well, but it was rather slow work, and people ran away almost every time. Wasn't there somewhere better?

That was when Toren realized there *was* somewhere he could be. He looked up instinctively, his head turning south...south east. There was something in that direction. Or rather, something called to him, prodded at some sense in the skeleton's mind.

It wasn't far away, and it intrigued Toren. That was as good a place to start as any. So the skeleton quickly unearthed the battered bronze armor he'd hid in the snow and put it on. So adorned, he began to march through the snow. He was going to level up! Level up and then—

And then he'd see whether or not he felt like killing Erin Solstice. Of a certainty, he was going to kill Lyonette and everyone else who'd annoyed him at that damn inn.

This is a story of a band of Goblins. They were a dangerous band of warriors—no common Goblins with rusted weapons and feeble bodies, but armed elites. Each one was over Level 10 in a combat class, and they were all armed and armored.

From their levels alone, they were each a match for any Bronze-rank adventurer. But in terms of experience, they were vastly more competent than any greenhorn with a sword. Each of the Goblins was a veteran warrior, one of the best fighters in the Redfang tribe.

And they were being led by a Hobgoblin. With him at their head, the Goblins were more than a match for any unprepared Silver-rank team. They were thirteen strong, a band of Goblin warriors.

And they were lost.

None of them mentioned this fact, however. They walked through the snow, rough cloaks held up against the wind as they marched on in tight

formation. They were elite warriors, able to cope with any threat. What was being lost compared to fighting a Wyvern?

The trouble was, it was hard to fight sore feet and the nagging feeling that you were in the wrong place when you should be doing something else. The truth was, this group of Goblins was ill-suited for their task.

Namely: kill the Human. And that was the problem. When the Goblin warriors had been given their task by their Chieftain, the famous Garen Redfang himself, it had all seemed too easy. They'd immediately set out after being dropped off by Carn Wolves close to where the Human had last been spotted, walking on foot and away from the main roads to avoid unnecessary conflicts.

But then pesky questions had begun circulating throughout the group. Doubts that plagued even the most stalwart members. Questions like, which Human? Where was she going? Why an [Innkeeper]? Was there danger? Would she be protected? Was she going to go into a city and if so—were they expected to fight their way in? And most importantly...

Why not tell their current Chieftain, Rags?

All of these questions were pressing and important, but perhaps none more so than the last one. That was because while the Goblin warriors were fine with a little geographical displacement, or even chronological displacement if it came to that, they weren't comfortable with disobeying their leader. And Rags was their leader, not Garen.

It was a complicated situation. In fact, for the Goblins, this current moment was the most politically fraught time any of them had ever experienced. Normally, being a Goblin was simple. All you had to do was survive, and obey the Chieftain. There wasn't even a third requirement. That was how simple it was.

But in a strange twist of fate, the Redfang tribe, invincible in the region around the High Passes that they'd claimed for themselves, had suddenly become subservient to a tribe that up until very recently had been little more than a ragtag group of weaklings, even by Goblin standards. But the new, young and undeniably attractive Rags was a decisive and intelligent Chieftain who'd conquered many tribes by force.

Even so, Garen Redfang would have been able to crush her by himself. And he nearly did—except that he'd thrown the battle between him and her. All the Goblins knew it. Garen had taken only part of his forces to fight her, and he'd raided her tribe with quick attacks rather than commit to a full

battle except at the end. He'd given the position of Chieftain over all the tribes to her.

That wasn't actually the problem either, though. Garen was a great warrior and an excellent leader in battle. But as a Chieftain his abilities to manage his tribe were below even a common Hob's which is why Rag's sudden leadership had been welcome. Even if she was only technically a Chieftain directing other smaller Chieftains rather than a Lord in control of all the tribes...it was much better than having Garen in that role.

And yet Garen was still somehow in charge, or at least, he acted like it. And he'd told the Goblin warriors not to tell Rags, which was odd because he shouldn't have been ordering them around to begin with if he *wasn't* the Chieftain or if she hadn't told him to.

It was all very complicated, and because it made the Goblins' heads hurt, they'd just gone along with what Garen had said. But now, as they marched along and looked for a girl whose name they didn't even know...

They were lost. None of the Goblins said it. At first, it had been too embarrassing to say. Saying it would have been a sign of weakness, or doubt in their former Chieftain's orders. They'd faithfully hunted for the Human female [Innkeeper] day after day, keeping silent, maintaining the illusion.

By this point, not saying they were lost was a point of pride among the warriors. As if by not saying it, it would somehow make things better than if they were admitting they were lost.

Still, it was day six and something had to be done. The warriors eyed each other as they walked, and the Hobgoblin leading them grunted irritably. This couldn't continue. Some of them had mates they wanted to get back to, and others were simply and understandably bored of walking around in circles.

All twelve normal Goblins and the Hobgoblin in charge were male. It wasn't that Goblin women couldn't be warriors—it was just that mostly, they were too busy being pregnant or taking care of children. But of the female Goblin warriors that did exist, none had been chosen to go on this mission.

Mainly because all the Goblins would have fought for her attention, including the Hob. And she might have fought them back if they got annoying. And the fighting would lead to sex, and the sex would lead to

babies. And before long, it wouldn't be a group of Goblin warriors wandering around, but another tribe.

The first Goblin to break the unspoken rule of silence was Badarrow. That wasn't his name of course—the Redfang tribe had no Shaman, so they had no names. And unlike Rags who had been named by a Human of all people, and Garen Redfang who had *two* names, none of these warriors had any proper name.

So instead they had nicknames, which were as good as names except that they weren't actual names. The Goblin who irritably made a comment in their primitive language as they sat around the fire was named Badarrow.

Badarrow was so named for his hatred of poor quality ammunition. Rather unusually for a Goblin, he refused to even touch any arrow with poor fletching, misshapen arrowheads, or bent shafts. He was an excellent [Archer] and he had the distinction of having killed two Silver-rank adventurers in battle, although this was slightly less impressive when you considered that he had just sat comfortably behind the actual fighting and taken both adventurers by surprise.

Nevertheless, he was a strong warrior and didn't care for the opinions of anyone else. Which is why he scowled and said a Goblin curse word as he snatched the bowl of watery mush the Goblins had made for lunch.

It was just pasted roots and a tiny bit of meat and bones they'd saved from one of the hares Badarrow had shot yesterday. It wasn't a bad meal for a normal Goblin, but the Redfang warriors were used to meat meals and lots of them.

All Badarrow said was the curse word, but it was the opening of a metaphysical discussion for the Goblins. It was true that their language was extremely primitive, but the Goblins made up for that fault by reading deeply into each other's body language and feelings. Goblins lived in close-knit quarters, so their ability to read each other almost bordered on the telepathic.

Badarrow's comment was indeed aimed at their poor food, but it was also a remark on the person who'd put them in a situation where all they could eat was this. It was an attack on Garen Redfang's leadership—a subject on which even his tribe was split—and obliquely, a reminder that the Goblins had a better leader whom they were not obeying by being here without her knowledge or permission.

The Goblins considered this comment for only a second. Many would have refused to dive into an argument with Badarrow, but the Hobgoblin, known as Grunter, just grabbed one of the shoddy wooden bowls and downed his gruel in one go. Then he grunted. His name was largely obvious to most Goblins, although some still needed to have it explained to them.

On first glance, Grunter was just burping, or grunting irritably as was his wont. But his prompt, business-like consumption of his meal indicated to the other Goblins that he at least was ready to keep following orders.

That came as no surprise, really. Hobs sometimes questioned their Chieftain, or even fought for the leadership spot, but those who had no such ambitions were always rock-steady behind their Chieftain. So Grunter's interjection was not a response so much as an opening statement warning the other Goblins that they were still largely indebted to Garen Redfang, despite their current predicament.

The next to comment was a Goblin sitting next to Grunter. He was known as Headscratcher—not for penchant for deep thought, but rather because he probably had lice. He poked his sword with one claw, a reminder of their task. But he also took a bite of his gruel, and even though his had a few fragments of meat, he made an unhappy face.

The other Goblins held their breath. This was a deep statement that cut to the core of what they were doing. Headscratcher had pointed out that yes, they were being sent to kill a Human. Nothing was wrong about that, but it was another reminder of Rag's relationship to Humans.

Word got around. Even though the Redfang tribe hadn't mingled long with the Flooded Waters Tribe, they knew Rags was friendly with at least one Human. And she often stayed at an inn. If this was the very same [Innkeeper] they'd been sent to kill, they would most certainly be in deep trouble for doing anything to her.

And Headscratcher's commentary on their food also pertained to their likely fate if Rags used her power as Chieftain to expel them from the tribe. Garen Redfang couldn't prevent that, and Headscratcher made it clear that this living rough was not for him.

The next to make a move were two Goblins, Bugear and Rocksoup. Bugear picked one of the infested mites out of his ear and flicked it at Headscratcher, which earned him a glare, but it put him solidly in Garen's camp. So what if things were hard now? Their duty was to obey.

Rocksoup clearly had other opinions. He'd added his secret ingredient to his bowl, despite the intestinal problems it always gave him, but now he quite deliberately dropped a dirty rock in the communal pot hanging over the fire. The other Goblins scowled, but the meaning was clear: what harmed one Goblin harmed them all. If Rags was their Chieftain, then disobeying her by following Garen hurt the entire tribe.

And yet, Grunter opined with another grunt of displeasure as he fished out the stone with two fingers, Garen had lead them. He'd helped them become the warriors they were, and even if he wasn't Chieftain, wasn't he still stronger than Rags? Did they not owe him their loyalty, even though they obeyed Rags too?

Badarrow derisively scratched at his armpit, a commentary on Garen Redfang—he might also have just been scratching an itch. He took out two arrows – one perfectly made, the other one with a single crooked bit of fletching from staying in the quiver. He snapped the imperfect arrow with one clawed hand.

Such a dramatic statement against their former boss quieted the other Goblins. But they knew Badarrow was right. Life had been hard sometimes, for the Redfang tribe. If not for the warriors, then the regular Goblins—there was never enough food, despite their ability to take down almost any monster they wanted. The Hobs had to do all the work, and as Grunter grudgingly admitted, Garen often made mistakes when it came to choosing campsites or places to hunt.

Rags was clearly the better Chieftain. That much all the Goblins could agree on. But the fierce debate that ensued revolved around whether or not her qualifications as a leader made her a better candidate than Garen Redfang, who was unmatched in terms of combat prowess. Complicating the issue was that he had yielded to her, but clearly only obeyed her instructions at his whim, preferring to work behind her back when it suited him.

Could they really go against their leader? And what would be the consequences of throwing their lot behind Rags? Would she protect them, or despise their cowardice in abandoning their own tribe? After all, although she directly led several tribes, the others were simply following her in a coalition. She was not their direct leader—the other Chieftains were simply subservient to her. She was no Goblin Lord. But could she be?

The complexity of such a debate might have stunned any Human who was able to interpret their seemingly random gestures—and even more willing to ignore their fairly disgusting displays while they sat and ate. Bugear was especially hard to watch as he dug around in the ear where at least one nest of insects had made their home.

Most people assumed Goblins were about as deep as a puddle, and that was broadly speaking true. But some puddles are actually underground lakes, at least in certain cases.

The Goblin warriors were, even in their own minds, rather unintelligent and uninformed about many worldly matters. But even if these Goblins couldn't perform wonders of mathematics or figure out how to read a map, they were still Goblins, experts in the field of Goblin culture in their own right. They understood tribal dynamics, and so they naturally debated such issues with keen interest.

After all, it was not unknown for Hobs or Goblin warriors to sway the outcome of a showdown between Chieftains. And the only thing Goblins had going for them was that they stuck together, regardless of what happened. So their hot debate was precisely the sort of thing that needed to occur to prevent internecine strife, which would be disastrous to their tribe.

In the end, the ones who formed the core of the debate were those who had been first to speak. Badarrow, Headscratcher, Grunter, Bugear, and Rocksoup were probably the best fighters, and certainly the most vocal. So the other Goblins deferred to them as they listened, only interjecting occasionally by flicking a stone at someone or passing wind to mock a stupid remark.

The others had names too of course, but the Goblins had only a limited amount of patience for remembering things. So often, the easiest way for them to think of each other was 'that Goblin' or 'other Goblin' and so on. Even when it came to themselves. It was only a nickname after all—if they had real names, they would have cared much more. But no one here was that lucky.

The Goblins spent around forty minutes eating lunch, upon which they packed up and kept walking in a random direction Grunter pointed. All the while they argued, until all of the Goblins present came to a conclusion as one.

Their general consensus was this: Garen Redfang was their Chieftain and leader. But—and this was a hard admission—he was a very poor

Chieftain. He was unmatched in battle, but outside of it he was about as useful as an arrow up the butt. That was to say, he was actually more of a hindrance than anything else.

True, he'd lost the battle on purpose to Rags. But hadn't she done a good job beating him and the other warriors despite that? The band of Goblins bore no particular ill will towards her for killing their comrades—they were just glad it hadn't been them. The trap with the Shield Spider pits had proven she could outmaneuver Garen, and if you added that to her ability to lead so many tribes...

There was no comparison. Rags was the Chieftain, and Garen had forgotten that. Grunter and Bugear put it down to his interactions with Humans. He'd forgotten that he had to obey Rags, not make decisions for her. He had to be reminded of that.

So the conclusion all the Goblins came to was simple: they had to go back. They would go back to Rags and tell her what Garen had told them to do. And then, depending on what she said they'd complete their mission or not. Garen would throw a fit and maybe he'd get violent—

But it was the right thing to do. Their tribe needed unity now, more than ever. Especially if there really was a Goblin Lord about to attack them. Neither Rags nor Garen were as good as a true Goblin Lord, despite their Skills. But if they worked together...

In truth, the Goblin warriors didn't know why they weren't joining with this Goblin Lord, as was customary. But they'd heard dark rumors about this so-called Lord, and Garen Redfang had told them that any Goblin who joined the Goblin Lord, he, Garen, would kill himself. Which told the Goblins a lot about how much this new Goblin Lord could be trusted.

That was a matter for later. Right now, they had to get back and throw their support behind Rags. The Goblins present were few, but they had a lot of clout even outside their own tribe. Grunt was an average Hobgoblin, but the warriors present were some of the best, and their voices would sway a lot of minds.

So! Time to go back! No more being lost. They could return with their heads held high. The Goblins all felt rather satisfied with themselves. Rather cleverly, they'd managed to address their current issue *without* having to bring up the fact that they were lost.

But then Headscratcher looked around at the snowy landscape. He scratched his head, stared at whatever was caught in his fingernails and

brought up a dismaying point.

Did they actually know where Rags and the other Goblins were right now?

The Goblin warriors looked at each other in consternation. They scratched their heads, scratched their butts, kicked at the snow, and shrugged helplessly. After a few seconds they all agreed. They were lost.

All eyes turned to Grunter. He grunted irritably. Grunter was a heavy Hob, one of the ones who was classically almost as wide as he was tall. He was no athletic Garen with a Human's build, but his weight helped in battle where he could use his axe to literally crush his opponents. And it also made him a rock of confidence in times like these.

After a few seconds of thought, Grunter pointed. Not in a random direction this time—he pointed towards where they had come.

Liscor. That was the place to be. That was where Rags and the others had last been—they could head that way. They were sure to pick up signs of so many Goblins moving, even with their pathetic tracking abilities.

All the Goblins agreed. They would go to Liscor. In less than an hour they found the main road heading south and, after walking north for a few hours before they realized their mistake, they stealthily shadowed the road heading south.

They were going to rejoin their tribe. The only problem was that none of the Goblins knew that Rags and Garen and all the Goblin tribes in the area had already headed north, far north to the area around Invrisil. The band of Goblins were going in the wrong direction.

But they didn't know that. And they felt confident, and that was all that mattered. That was, until they saw the other Goblins marching down the road.

This is the story of a young woman. She had a name. But she had no words to tell anyone her name, even if they would have listened to her. She had lost language. And she had lost her family and everything else.

Before—she had a life. She'd been a [Florist]—an unusual class, but one she could take because her city had been beautiful and peaceful. Esthelm had been a happy city.

And then the Goblins came. The girl only remembered the chaos and screaming—shouting confusion as everyone ran. She'd tried to find her family, to escape, but the streets had been full of dark shapes, and the Goblins—

They had come and gone, and left a burned city in their wake. The girl had survived the fire, and she had been one of the first to lay eyes on her broken home.

Esthelm had been destroyed in a single night. And what remained was —

Rubble. Broken buildings. A maze of fallen masonry and tunnels of homes where the dead lay buried in the darkness. Empty souls wandering the destruction, preying on each other.

If she had found her family, she might have left with them. But no help had come, and the young woman had found herself trapped in the city. The Goblin army had left—leaving countless numbers of their dead in the streets. Goblins had slaughtered their own kind and plundered the city. Perhaps some would have called it a mercy.

But not her. And not the survivors. Rather, the many who survived the Goblin attack soon realized the true horror of what the Goblins had done. The monsters had taken goods, plundered valuables—and stolen away the food. And now, in the remains of their city, over half of the remaining population began to tear each other apart over what scraps they could find.

Death by sword or fire would have been the kinder alternative by far. The young woman had tried to find her home, and then find stores of food—shops—but she had found nothing. Desperate men and women had killed each other fighting over a bag of grain before her eyes, and she had fled.

Now she sat in the dark, broken place that had been a home, staring up at a ceiling held up by crumbling supports. Even though the structure could fall at any moment, she didn't care. Oblivion was preferable to what she faced.

Hungry. She was so hungry. It wasn't even words anymore. Just an overpowering desire to eat something. Anything.

It had been six days. Six long days since Esthelm had burned. The young woman's clean hair was gone. Her features were gaunt. Her stomach was eating away at the rest of her body. She was so hungry.

And yet—she could find no food. Now she sat, staring at the one thing she could find to eat. But it was too horrible. She turned away and lay

against a broken wall, trying to die. Trying to ignore the nightmarish idea in her brain.

On the seventh day she stared down at the body. Even flies hadn't found it yet. Whoever it had been—male or female—had burned in the devastation. Their skin was blackened. And yet—

The smell. It was nauseating, horrific. The burnt flesh should have made her turn away and puke. But now it only made her mouth water. Her stomach growled. The young woman stared at the body, possessed by a terrible urge.

Hungry. She was hungry.

She couldn't. She would rather die. But when she'd pulled herself to the entrance of her hidden resting place, she'd seen what lay outside. Bands of men—grabbing young women, fighting each other. She'd watched in horror and retreated to her small place, covering her ears to not hear the shrieks.

On the eighth day she stared at the body. She was forcing herself not to touch it. She stared at the ground. She stared at her hands, ragged, dirty. She tried to tell herself it would never happen.

Hungry.

But something dark sat up in her body. It crawled towards the light, and salivated in the madness of her broken mind. When she heard the screaming outside—inhuman and bestial, she'd smiled and laughed uncontrollably, giggling in the silence of her pit.

And on the ninth day, she'd eaten the body. It was rotten and the flesh was—

She tore and bit like an animal, lost to reason. The only desire she had in the entire world was to eat.

She was so hungry it hurt. But then she ate and ate and—

And then it happened. She heard the voice in her mind as she slept that night, after she'd puked and wept and eaten again, letting the monster in her soul take over. She ate and ate and ate until her body was *gorged* on the flesh, eating until she thought she would burst. And then she'd heard the voice in her head.

[Rank 1 Horror – Corpse Eater.]

[Condition – Terrible Hunger Received.]

[Condition – Outcast Humanity Received.]

[Aspect – Body of the Eater Obtained.]

[Aspect – Rending Claws Obtained.]

[Florist Level 19 → Florist Level 16.]

[Skill – Aroma of Spring Lost.]

[Skill – Winter Growth Lost.]

She'd woken up and screamed. But the sound hadn't been Human. And when she'd felt at her teeth suddenly sharp and pointed, her fingernails like razors and her face—she'd known.

She'd become a monster. She had damned herself and lost her humanity. She was—

So hungry. So very, very hungry.

And there was food to eat everywhere now. So much food.

Esthelm, in the darkness. It always seemed dark in Esthelm. The broken buildings and slanted walls created a labyrinth into which sound and light seemed to vanish. The bands of refugees and thugs who'd established themselves on the outside of the city had light, but it only served to enshroud the center of the city in more darkness.

The sewers had broken in places. In others, the flame had sent buildings tumbling into obscene heaps of death. Only the brave and truly desperate would go searching in these places, even among Esthelm's survivors. Because even if they did not see anything, they knew dark things lurked in these places.

One of these dark things looked like a young woman. Perhaps. She had ragged long hair and her body was in the right shape. But clothing hung from her thin frame, and as she tore at something on the ground, other changes were clear. Her fingernails were sharp like knives. Her hands and face looked—wrong. And she was eating.

She crouched on the ground, tearing at something. She stuffed pieces into her face, rotting bits of...something. Something she still couldn't put into words.

Because she'd lost them.

[Rank 2 Horror – Carrion Eater.]

[Condition – Wordless Thing Received.]
[Skill – Gaping Bite Obtained.]

[Florist Level 16 → Florist Level 12.]
[Skill – Quick Growth Lost.]

The more she ate, the worse it became. But now she was eating the rotting corpses, not just the burned dead. She was so hungry. Part of her wanted to puke, but she could only eat. It was all—

Delicious. Not like sweets or savory foods to make the mouth water, but something more primal. It was just food she tasted—food to fill the hole in her stomach. So she ate and bit, and chewed the bones.

Part of her wanted to die. But the rest was just hungry. She could stop herself for only a few seconds. And then her head would lower and she would *feast*.

The young woman pulled more of the corpse towards her. It had been a woman, once. A young woman, like her. The knowledge was a dagger in the girl's heart, but she couldn't stop. She bit once, and again, tearing off bits and pieces, feeling the flesh rip and stretch. Tears ran down her face, and she choked on bile and the foulness. But she swallowed and bit again.

So hungry. She was so hungry. And she had to eat. Had to. It was that or become one of the rotting bodies. She wanted to be dead, but she couldn't figure out how.

The girl reached for the head of the half-devoured woman. And then she heard the scream.

“No!”

She saw the movement, saw the blow coming. It smashed into her face, making her nose *crunch* and her flesh tear as the boot struck her. Then she heard the man.

“What are you *doing*? Dead gods—what—?”

Then the orb of light in his hands shone on her and she shielded her face. The man saw the corpse and he went still. The young woman looked up, gasping, searching for words. But they had all left her.

And as the horror-struck man's eyes turned from the body to her face, he recoiled. He went pale, and his voice shook as he spoke.

“Monster.”

He whispered it, and then screamed the word.

“Monster!”

She backed away on all fours as he groped around for a weapon, a stone—anything. She saw him find a piece of wood, splintered on one end. He raised the block of wood and advanced, swinging at her.

“Get away—die you—you monster!”

She fled. He chased after her, catching her with one bloody swing on the shoulder once—but he quickly gave up the chase. She looked back only once and saw him holding the body in his arms.

This was her life.

They found her as she fled. A group of laughing men, desperate and lacking hope, but reveling in their own twisted freedom to do as they pleased. They only saw her silhouette in the flickering light of their torches, but they called out the instant they saw her.

“A woman!”

“Come here!”

They chased her too. She fled down a broken street, tripping, stumbling. One of them had a Skill and they caught up to her quickly. But the group of men stopped when their torches cast her body into relief. The color drained from their faces as they saw her face, her clothing—when they saw her.

“What is—”

“Is she—is it—?”

They might have killed her, but she fled into a broken place where the rubble had fallen and broken into a sewer. None of the men chased her. Their lust was gone, and only horror remained.

In the muck and congealed foulness, the thing that used to be a girl saw something moving. She darted after it even as it fled. But it was too slow, and she was too quick now. Hunger and her new form drove her, made her quick. Quicker than the shambling dead things that tried to follow her. She could see them rising in the darkness. The dead coming back to life.

But she wasn't interested in them. Small creatures were easier to kill. And the rodent she'd found was slow in the sewer waste. Too slow.

She caught a rat and held it up. It struggled and screamed in her hands and bit her, but the pain was just like everything else that was life. And when she bit *it*, the body twitched a few times and then was still.

She ate it entirely, and licked at her foul hands. It didn't matter. She was lost. And then she wailed, screaming with all that remained of her heart.

The noise attracted the shambling things. They came for her, rotting, trying to kill her. But she was quick, and she fled. But the dead were coming back, all of them. Some climbed out of the sewers and more dug themselves out of the ground. They were coming back.

Somehow, it made the former girl happy. Esthelm was as damned as she was.

A vast army of them, far larger than any one tribe's worth of warriors was marching down the road. The band of Goblins halted immediately, and fear ran down all of their spines. In an instant, they knew these were not Goblins from their tribe, or even the amalgamate led by Rags and Garen.

The instant the Goblin warriors saw the army, they knew something was wrong. Though the tide of green bodies were unmistakably Goblins and Hobgoblins, there was something wrong about this company.

They were Goblins, yes. But they were not Goblins who followed Rags or Garen. These Goblins wore armor, and all carried weapons. And they marched with death among them and on their blades.

Death, and far worse than that.

Some carried pikes with human and monster parts dangling from them. Others simply marched in place, but that was wrong too. They moved like a Human or Drake army, in formation, not freely like the band of Goblins did. Their armor was black, and they covered their faces with dark helmets and cloth, as if they were afraid to show their faces.

Badarrow snarled as he pointed to the front ranks of Goblins. Headscratcher, Grunter, and the others looked, and saw dead Goblins. Undead Goblins, that was.

Several rows of zombies walked in front of the main army, shambling along. Mostly Goblins, but Humans, Drakes, and Gnolls too. There was a [Necromancer] among the Goblins, or a [Shaman] capable of raising the dead.

The Goblin Warriors had no problem with mages. At least, no problem with ones on their side. Garen's tribe had no Shamans and they were rare. But necromancers bothered even Goblins. The dead could be eaten or left to rot—or even be used to hide amongst in order to survive. But raising their own fallen to fight again?

That was cruel, even for Goblins. But what was worse was what it said about a Chieftain who would order his [Shamans] to raise the dead. It meant he would use his tribe like things, and have them fight and die for him even after they had died the first time.

This was no tribe of Goblins north of Liscor. Without having to be told, the band of Goblins knew that this was a force sent by the Goblin Lord to the south.

And worst—what made Bugear stop poking at his ear and Rocksoup turn gray with fear—all the Goblins knew that this wasn't the actual full force of the Goblin Lord. No—they saw no women and children among the army. This was clearly a war band sent out to pillage and kill. And for such a huge one to be sent—how terribly vast was the host of the Goblin Lord?

It was not a question they had time to ponder. The Goblin army had spotted the thirteen Goblins the same time they had been spotted. The Goblin warriors saw Goblins on foot and others riding ponies, and even what looked like *spiders*, approaching them at speed.

Perhaps they thought they were allies? No one had begun loosing arrows yet or casting spells.

Grunter, their leader, made a decision in a moment. He turned and shouted an order. All thirteen Goblins turned and fled up the road. They heard shouts among their pursuers, and then knew they were being chased.

Arrows flew towards them. But the Goblin Warriors had a good bit of distance on their pursuers, so they ignored the shots. Badarrow and two other Goblins turned and loosed arrows at the fastest pursuers—Badarrow's shot took a pony in the leg and the animal *screamed* as it went down with the rider. The scream cut off quickly and the Goblin rose with a dripping blade.

The Goblin warriors ran on. They had no idea where they were going or what to do; they only knew they *had* to flee or die.

That was how they found the city. It appeared on their right side as the road curved towards it, a broken place, the walls torn down and the gates

forced open. It was destroyed, but the Goblin warrior headed towards it without a second's hesitation.

There might be Humans living here. It *had* been a Human city after all. But even if there were survivors, it would be easier to lose their pursuers among the rubble and fight in tight alleyways than be caught out on the open, snowy landscape where there was nowhere to hide.

The band of Goblins ran furiously, outdistancing even their mounted pursuers by the expedient of shooting down any who got too close. The pursuing Goblins halted when they saw they'd lose their quarry, and rejoined the main army. As the marching army of the Goblin Lord approached the city, a vanguard split off, marching slowly towards Esthelm. There was no need to hunt the individual Goblins. The vanguard had been sent to subjugate what remained of the city, and they could kill the warriors from the other tribe just as easily in the process.

That was how Goblins came back to Esthelm. Some fleeing, others seeking the city out for darker purposes.

The skeleton walked towards Esthelm, understanding more and more as he walked why he was headed there.

It was a place of death. He could sense it in the air. Esthelm had seen hundreds—thousands of lives claimed. And the dead were lying unburied, rotting, forming a mass of—of opportunity. That was how Toren thought of it.

Yes, opportunity was the right word. It wasn't as if there was any inherent will here. But the dead were gathered so close that magic only had to fluctuate a bit and the dead would come back. It was a natural process, and Toren understood it almost instinctively.

The undead. The skeleton considered the idea as he marched down the empty road, the snow blowing against his battered armor. He knew he was technically undead, but he felt little kinship with the skeletons, zombies, and other creatures he was related to. To him, they were just other things he could kill, or rather, re-kill.

And why not? Toren was sure that he would level if he fought some powerful undead. Perhaps there would be Crypt Lords in the city. The thought of fighting one of them cheered him up greatly, and he ran towards

the city instead. After all, it wasn't as if he would get tired running, and it was faster than walking.

That was how he found the vanguard of Goblins. They spotted him as he ran towards the city. Toren stopped when he saw them. The skeleton didn't have any real fear in his heart, so his only reaction to seeing the hundreds of Goblins wearing arms and armor was mild surprise.

That was a lot of Goblins. And then Toren had another thought: fighting them would probably be a bad idea, at least, if he tried to do it all at once.

Should he run? Toren was fairly certain that he could get away from any number of Goblins, even in armor. But before he could make up his mind, he saw movement at the core of the army.

Not all the Goblins were armored infantry. Some were riders, others Hobs. And one in the center wore no armor at all. Instead, the Goblin had a twisted staff of ivory bones that looked welded together. And his eyes glowed with a darker crimson than the other Goblins. He gestured at Toren, and spoke a word that was audible even across the vast distance between them.

It was a word of magic, a word in the Goblin tongue, but magic nonetheless. Toren *jerked* as he felt something in his head.

Come here. The words burned in Toren's mind. He faltered—and then realized the words were like one of Erin's orders! Immediately, his body turned and he began walking straight towards the Goblin [Shaman]. The other Goblins parted to let him pass, ignoring Toren's armor and burning gaze. They all wore grim expressions—as far as Toren could tell from their odd faces. They were used to the dead—Toren saw quite a few zombies and some skeletons marching at the head of the army.

At first, Toren was just shocked. He let his body move, unable to comprehend what had happened. How had the Goblin ordered him? But his shock quickly turned to rage.

He was being *ordered* against his will. Again! But Toren held his patience. He didn't struggle against the command. Instead, he marched straight up to the [Shaman].

The Goblin was old, and he rode on a cart next to a Goblin seated on a large Shield Spider. The mounted Goblin had black tattoos all over his body and a gleaming halberd. The two Goblins were talking in their own language, and Toren saw the [Shaman] was eying him with some interest.

As the skeleton approached, the [Shaman] turned from his conversation with the Goblin leader and beckoned towards the skeleton. Toren approached, and the Goblin eyed him from head to toe. He spoke several words in his own language, nodding encouragingly.

Toren nodded to himself as well. So, some spell casters could control him? This was an important discovery. However, there was something different about the spell that controlled him now and Erin's orders. This [Shaman]'s words—the ones that made Toren draw his sword and slash the air a few times and stand at attention—they felt weaker somehow.

Well now, wasn't that interesting? The [Shaman] waved Toren towards the other undead standing at the head of the army. Toren cocked his head, and then walked.

Forwards, not towards the other undead. At first, the [Shaman] didn't seem to notice Toren approaching. But when the Goblin leader made an inquisitive sound, he turned and saw Toren walking towards him.

The [Shaman]'s eyes widened. He gestured towards the undead and croaked an unmistakable order. Toren paused mid-step and then kept walking.

Surprisingly, the [Shaman] didn't try to run or fight. He just kept trying to recast the spell, which Toren found hilarious. The skeleton walked right up to the Goblin and paused in front of him.

Flabbergasted, the [Shaman] just stared at Toren in shock. Toren slowly raised a hand, and waved it slowly at the Goblin. The Goblin stared at him, and then raised his hand hesitantly as well. He waved it—

And Toren ran him through with his sword. The skeleton ignored the shouts of panic and the cry of rage from the Goblin leader. He just smiled—smiled as he always did as the [Shaman] choked in shock and pain.

The Goblin spellcaster stared into Toren's flaming sockets as the skeleton twisted the sword. Toren yanked the blade out of the Goblin's body and watched him fall to the ground, dead.

Good. Toren turned, and the shining halberd cut his arm off. He reeled backwards, surprised. The Goblin Leader snarled at him, cutting through Toren's bronze armor with ease.

One-handed, Toren struck at the Goblin. But the leader pulled his mount away and shouted an order. Every Goblin in the army charged at Toren—and he was standing in the center of their force.

Oh well. Toren lifted his sword and grinned again. He charged at the Goblins. He *cut* and *stabbed* even as the Goblin warriors overwhelmed him. They pierced his armor and broke his bones. But still the skeleton refused to fall.

Only when the Goblin with the halberd came back to sever Toren's head from his shoulders did the skeleton's body crumble. The Goblins saw his bones fall to the ground and stomped them into the snow. They stared at his remains, and muttered amongst themselves until their leader snapped an order.

The [Shaman]'s body was stripped of all valuables, and his body tossed into a pile of corpses towed by two half-dead horses. Two lesser [Shamans] came forwards, cringing and uncertain as the Goblin leader ordered them to take command of the undead. They'd gone rampant after the [Shaman] had died, and the remaining spellcasters had to work to keep them in order.

But in the end, the Goblin vanguard set out again. They marched towards Esthelm—but halted several miles away from the city rather than enter it. They had lost their chief [Shaman] through some twist of fate, and messengers had to be sent back to the main force which had continued northwards. Until they could receive reinforcements to control the dead, there would be no point in entering the city. After all, what good was a city of the dead and soon to be dead if you couldn't control them with magic?

Still, a few Goblin groups were sent towards the city, to scout out how many Humans had survived. Something had killed the first army sent here, and although the city was clearly in ruins, it never hurt to be cautious. If there were still traces of Humans, the Goblins would slaughter them. Shaman or no shaman, they could still prepare the way.

The Goblins waited. And so did Toren. He waited until they were all gone to reassemble himself. He stood up in the snow, dusting off his bones and staring in dismay at his ruined armor.

What a waste. And how odd! Toren was sure these weren't the Goblins led by that Rags Goblin. So where had they come from?

He didn't really care. In fact, Toren was privately delighted. Now he had both Goblins *and* undead he could kill! And Humans too!

He marched into the city, leaving his battered armor behind. All he needed was a sword. That was all. A sword and something to stab.

He was going to level up a *lot* in the city. But—carefully. Toren was aware that even he could only reanimate so many times. He'd have to

ambush the Goblins, fight in the shadows.

That was fine. Toren could see in the dark.

So the skeleton walked into the city, keeping to the shadows, enjoying the opportunity he had found here. As he did, the band of thirteen Goblins ran fast and as far as they could, dodging into buildings, trying to find a place to hide, to survive the pursuit that was surely coming after them. And all the while they feared what lay in the city. Monsters? Humans? This was a nightmare for them.

Meanwhile, a nightmare stalked the streets. She hid from the Humans she encountered, and wept as she ate and scavenged among the dead. And the dead rose and tried to kill her as well. There was little left of her, but she clung to what fragments remained. She lived and ate. She survived. That was all she knew. She was...lost.

This is the story of a skeleton named Toren. This is the story of a band of lost Goblins. This is the story of a monster. And how they all met in a city where the dead lived and the living struggled.

Esthelm.

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3.18 T

This is a story of a skeleton. His name was Toren, and it was the one thing he had never questioned about himself. Erin had given him that name, and that at least he was grateful to her for.

But in the place he walked, no one would know his name. In fact, they wouldn't even bother to ask whether he had one. The people in the city of Esthelm would probably just take one look at Toren and run, or try to kill him.

And if they *were* some kind of mentally-deficient human who wanted to make friends with an undead skeleton, Toren would kill them anyways. That was his plan, and he thought it was a good one.

The skeleton strolled in through the open gates of the city as dusk fell. He didn't worry about anyone stopping him; there were no guards manning the shattered watch towers, or what remained of the walls. And yet, he knew there were people in the city.

Lots of them, in fact. Toren stared as he walked further into the city and saw what remained after the Goblins' attack.

Broken buildings. Scorched ash. Piles of rubble and broken earth. Toren was no expert, but he was fairly certain this *wasn't* how cities were supposed to look.

Then again, maybe this was how Humans built their cities? Who knew? Toren spotted several...buildings amidst the shattered landscape. He stared, intrigued, at flimsy ramshackle structures someone had built out of salvaged wood and metal.

Were those supposed to be houses? They looked so flimsy, Toren felt he could push them over if he tried. And as it turned out, he could do just that. The skeleton succeeded in knocking over a support beam to one of the structures, which sent the roof and walls tumbling in. He paused as he heard screams from inside the structure, and then realized the noise had attracted people.

People, or to be more accurate, the one species that seemed to live in this city.

Humans.

They rushed over to the building and Toren quickly ran away from the scene of the destruction. He saw men and women in dirty and torn clothing dashing towards the caved-in structure. Crouched behind a broken wall, Toren saw some of them trying to pull away the debris that had collapsed on the people inside.

The building's inhabitants came out shaken, bloody, shocked. Toren saw with interest there were children—Human children—among them. He'd never seen a Human child before. After a few seconds of observation, Toren concluded they were nothing special. All they seemed to do was cry.

The skeleton saw the Humans—now a rather large group, perhaps thirty or more, exclaiming over the structure that had mysteriously fallen to bits. He saw a few of the Humans—mostly men—begin to point fingers at another man who was raising his hands and pointing frantically at the structure. One man—standing next to a woman holding a weeping child with a bloody shoulder in her arms—raised a fist. He punched the accused man, and then more people rushed to help him beat the poor fellow to death, or at least into something close to it.

It was all fascinating to Toren. He watched as the mob, having administered justice, began to try and figure out what to do next. It was cold, and snowflakes kept drifting down sporadically from the sky. The Humans had to find shelter soon, or at least blankets. There had been blankets in the building, so some tried to dig them out. But then another fight broke out over who should have the blankets, and then someone pulled out a dagger—

Confusion and chaos. This was only one small group, in a small part of the city. When Toren was done watching Humans attack each other, he found another group of Humans to see much of the same.

They certainly did like to fight, didn't they? They formed into groups or tried to survive on their own, quarreling and sometimes even killing each other over things like blankets, food, weapons—all of which, it had to be said, seemed to be in very short supply.

Toren quite approved of the violence he witnessed as he made his way deeper into the city, keeping to the shadows. He hadn't ever noticed Erin or Lyonette doing it, but Humans seemed to love hurting each other. Perhaps this was why he liked killing things?

The skeleton knew his bones—at least his skull—was Human. So he felt a certain kinship to the gangs of desperate men who banded together

and savagely attacked anyone weaker than them to steal what they needed or wanted. It was so fascinating to Toren that he completely forgot to kill anything for a while as he observed the refugees of Esthelm in their natural habitat.

He'd never seen so many Humans before! Not ever! In truth, Toren had never been to anything like a crowded place before; the closest he'd come were busy nights when Erin's inn had been packed. But this was different.

There were a *lot* of Humans. True, many of them seemed like they were crowded together in ramshackle structures, but it did seem like there was some kind of organization happening. The strongest Humans—those with weapons or some kind of fighting Skill—lead the others. They made sure their people had more clothing, more to eat. And they took other things as well.

A man dragged a screaming woman away after one group of men had killed another group of men. Toren followed him as he took the woman away and for some reason, took off his clothes. And then he did strange things which made no sense to the skeleton, but which seemed to upset the young woman.

Toren cocked his head left and then right, trying to figure out what the *point* was. There was a lot of grunting and animal-like motion...was that it? They were just sort of bumping each other, much to the woman's displeasure.

Maybe he wasn't seeing the full picture. Carefully, the skeleton crawled across the ground. It was easy for him to make himself invisible in places where snow had fallen, but it meant he couldn't see everything. He moved around and tried to get a good perspective from another angle.

Nope. No good. Frustrated, the skeleton stood up. He finally saw what the man was doing—about the same time as the man happened to glance up. He looked up and saw the skeleton staring at him. Toren stared down in interest as the man went white.

Well now, what was this? More fleshy bits. Toren had seen Erin naked a few times by accident, but he hadn't been aware there were so many differences between male Humans and female ones. And how strange the fleshy bits were! He ignored the man's horrified stare as he fixed his attention on a rather odd body part that was changing before his eyes. He had no idea things could *shrink* like that.

The man made a choking, horrified noise as the woman saw Toren. She screamed. He scrambled off her and grabbed for his weapon—a spiked club he'd carelessly tossed to the ground. Toren sneered at it silently. He let the man charge at him, naked, swinging his club without an inch of actual skill or forethought.

Humans.

Toren didn't even bother with his sword. He wrenched the club out of the man's hands as the Human struck at him, and then beat the man to the ground with it. The Human took quite a few blows to die, which Toren attributed to the shoddy craftsmanship of his club. He should have been ashamed.

When he was done, Toren tossed the bloody club on the ground. He stared at the woman, who hadn't really stopped screaming since he'd seen her. It was getting annoying, so Toren used the [Fear] effect in his eyes.

That made her freeze, shivering, naked, and terrified as she sat on the ground, staring at him. She flinched as Toren raised the club, but he just tossed it on the dead man's corpse. He could have beaten her to death with it as well, but she didn't seem like she was a warrior, so why bother?

In his experience, there wasn't actually much to be gained from slaughtering things that couldn't fight back. He'd tried it with baby spiders, the odd reptilian birds that lived around Liscor, and even Corusdeer fawns. There was just no point to it. It was fun, obviously, but Toren had come here for a reason.

Yes, he was here to fight! The skeleton abandoned the Humans, and indeed, the populated parts of the city entirely. He walked further into the center of the city, peering around demolished buildings. Groups of Humans hitting each other with sticks and occasionally swords was all very well, but he'd come here for a *real* challenge. Where were the undead? Probably further in. And the Goblin army had to be coming soon. Toren would have a fight then, but in the meantime, he searched around for trouble. There had to be actual warriors around here, right?

Right?

The Goblins ran through the city, no longer fleeing, but rather, searching for a place to hide.

Their pursuers had stopped at the edges of the city. But the Goblins kept moving, venturing deeper into the ruins of Esthelm. Now that they knew where they were, they were convinced of several things.

Firstly, this city had been destroyed. That was obvious. But what was clear to them was that this city had been ransacked in an odd way. The buildings and indeed the city's defenders had been put to sword and flame, yet the people had been spared. The instant the Goblins had entered the city they had spotted countless Humans, living in their camps on the outskirts of the city.

The Goblins had never seen anything like it. When they attacked a city or village, they killed all the inhabitants or forced them to flee. But this—taking the city but leaving the people to remain? Who would do such a thing?

It made them all think of Rags. Perhaps she had been here? They certainly saw evidence some Goblins had been here—an entire army's worth of dead Goblins lay slaughtered across the city, their rotting remains covered partially by the snow.

But maybe it had all been the Goblin Lords' forces? The Redfang Goblins didn't know. But they did know they couldn't stay in the open. Humans being in the city complicated things. Hiding from their own kind was one thing, but if there were this many Humans there, the Goblins had two enemies to fight.

Most of the Humans they passed had formed small groups—former [Shopkeepers] and [Butchers] and so on holding weapons they didn't know how to use. But if they all attacked the Redfang Goblins at once, the warriors would be torn to bits no matter how superior their equipment and levels were.

So the Goblin warriors ran. The other Goblins following them would come sooner or later, they knew. So they had to find a place to hide.

But where?

The first to spot a likely area was Bugear. He called out as they ran, and pointed to a collapsed building, taller than most structures. It was terribly exposed, but the other Goblins understood what he meant and immediately surged towards it. They raced down broken streets, ignoring the Humans that cried out and fled from them. Lone Humans weren't their concern.

The rubble was jagged and broken pieces of stone stood out, but the mound was easy to climb for the Goblins. In minutes they were all at the

top, staring down at the dark city below them.

They weren't hiding. Not yet. Rather, they were doing the sensible thing and taking the lay of the land, scoping out the city on their own terms. It was true they would be easily spotted, but who was looking for the Goblins right now? The Humans were disorganized and only a scant few of them had ranged weapons of any kind.

So the Redfang warriors held their position, staring down at Esthelm. Grunter ordered two Goblins – Leftstep and Rabbiteater – to watch for anyone trying to climb up and take them by surprise. Meanwhile, the other Goblins pointed down, their keen eyes catching individual Humans roaming the streets. And the Goblins exclaimed, their voices full of surprise.

What was this? What was this...city? What had happened here? Obviously the Humans had survived the battle, but what was this? They were forming groups, fighting over territory. See there? Headscratcher pointed out a group of men building a clumsy barricade to wall off a street. They were creating bases in the city! And already, some groups of Humans had created living spaces, communal campfires and places for the young and elderly to rest, guarded zealously by Humans who watched over their new home with improvised weapons.

It was startling, strange, unheard of. And to the Goblin warriors, deeply disturbing. Not because it was so unfamiliar—but because it was exactly like the life they knew. To them, it was like the Humans had formed Goblin tribes. They fought and warred over resources like Goblins did, only viciously, fighting over petty scraps that even the Goblin tribes wouldn't have contested.

If too many tribes were in the same region, they would fight. But the weaker tribe would move away rather than continue to fight. But none of the Humans left the city. They warred over it instead, building a new place on the ashes of their homes. It was so surreal to them that the Goblin warriors had to stop and take it all in.

And the cruelty! Ah, Goblins knew Humans could be cruel. But when they saw the other Humans killing each other in the streets, chasing after women, hurting—the Goblins saw a bit of what they did, and felt uneasy. It was too much like what Goblins were supposed to do. Not Humans.

Of course, not all Humans had become raping, murderous monsters. But it had to be said that the ones who did this tended to stand out a lot more than the ones just trying to survive. The Goblins stood on their position for

a few minutes, and after they were able to tear their eyes away from the Humans, they took in the rest of the city.

The places near the walls were the most populated. Only naturally—the destruction was actually less around the outskirts, since there weren't as many buildings that could have been destroyed. But in the center, a great pile of broken walls and stone formed a maze, a labyrinth that ran into the earth in places where the underground sewers had collapsed and sent the ground tumbling downwards.

That was a good place to hide. But for how long? At Grunter's insistence, the Goblins checked their supplies. They weren't carrying much. Aside from their weapons and tools to start fires and hunt and prepare food with, they had barely enough for a scant meal between them. If they wanted to live in this city, they'd have to find food.

Well, there were dead bodies. Badarrow pointed out some fresh ones. And there were Humans as well as Goblins for variety. Grunter nodded, but his eyes were on a few pinpoints of light beyond the city walls. The other Goblins looked.

Campfires. And they could see small shapes, hundreds of them, gathered around the fires. Goblins. Not their people, but the enemy.

Why were they here? It didn't matter. They'd boxed the Redfang Goblins into the city, and if they tried to run, they'd surely be cut down.

It was bad news. But the Goblins *were* Goblins, so they regarded their predicament as only another thing to survive. That was why they moved off the rubble and into the heart of the city without worrying or speaking. Shelter first, and then food. Worrying was pointless; a thing Chieftains did.

On their passage through the streets, the Goblins slowed. Now that they weren't running, they let their most silent trackers—Badarrow and Numbtongue—go ahead. Numbtongue peered down an alley and shook his head. The Goblins swiftly passed by the entrance, avoiding the group of Humans at the other end.

Fighting was pointless. The Goblins knew how to fight, which meant they knew when not to fight. They avoided any groups of Humans, slowly working their way deeper and deeper through the streets.

That's when they saw the Human and the child. He was calling out, searching for his family. The Goblins heard his voice and said nothing, although they all privately knew where the child's parents likely were.

Hadn't they all gone through the same moments growing up, after a battle or when their tribe had been raided?

Grunter wanted to move on, but Headscratcher pointed. The Goblins, hidden as they crouched in a shadowy spot next to a building, saw a man approaching the child. He had no weapon, but there was murder in the way he walked.

Perhaps he was tired of hearing the child call out. Maybe he thought the child would attract too much attention here. He might have been angry, or filled with hate. Maybe he just wanted to kill something.

The boy ran when he saw the adult. But he was too slow. The man grabbed him. The Goblins watched, remembering. It was a familiar scene. Still, they didn't move. They would have left, to let the scene play out, but Badarrow stood up. Silently, he put an arrow to his bow and loosed it.

Badarrow's shot took the Human in the back, right where neck met shoulder. The man gasped, fell, nearly squashing the shocked boy who cried out. He was dead when he hit the ground.

None of the other Goblins said a word. But neither did they rebuke Badarrow. And neither did they look at the child. They just paused, and moved on.

The wandering child screamed as he saw the Goblins, but the warriors moved past him, grim and silent. They gave him no aid, but didn't hurt him. He was Human. An enemy if he was older, prey if he had valuables they could take. What could they have done for him, anyways?

But the Redfang warriors exchanged glances even so, as they found likely spots to settle and scouted around for any fresh bodies and wood to use for dinner. They didn't say it, but they all thought it.

There was something dark in this city. Of course, they'd seen things far more terrifying than this, and they'd faced times just as bleak. But it was what the Humans did that disturbed the Goblins. When things fell apart, they didn't stick together like Goblins did—they tore each other apart. Hadn't they all been part of the same tribe here? Why were they killing each other now?

No one had an answer. But Grunter, who'd been staring at the sky, grunted. The Goblins looked at him as they pulled the Human that Badarrow had shot back towards their new base. The boy was long gone.

Grunter pointed the direction they'd come, back towards the other Goblins. He spoke, the words coming slowly to him.

“The others will come. Here. To kill the Humans.”

The Redfang warriors nodded. That was likely. They could put two and two together—even if this city had been looted, the Humans were a resource. Food, and perhaps even warriors if the [Shamans] and [Mages] they’d seen could control so many.

But what did that have to do with them? Grunter pointed at the broken walls, the maze the Goblins found themselves in. He touched the axe at his belt.

“Chaos. Confusion. Kill them.”

The Goblin warriors considered this. Then Bugear grinned and Rocksoup licked his lips. Now, *that* was a good idea! It was unlike Grunter to come up with it, but he was a Hob after all.

Kill their kind. Ambush them in the streets. Even if there was an army, it wasn’t impossible in this landscape. The city practically invited sneak attacks. And in the confusion and looting and killing, they could surely slip away from their pursuers.

After all, Goblins looked alike. And if they could get their hands on some armor—who’d notice a band of Goblins amidst all the fighting?

It was a good plan, and the Goblins wasted no more time thinking about it. They had a plan, and they would implement it as best they could. Now it was time to eat. They had one body—they could find more, and stuff themselves tonight.

That was one small benefit to be had from this city. There were a lot of bodies, and Humans didn’t eat dead Humans. So the Goblins would be fed, and warm too, if they could find enough wood. All they had to do was find a place to hide.

And wait.

Toren was getting sick of all the useless Humans. He was tempted to just run at a band of looters and fight them, but he had the feeling he wouldn’t level if he did. He strode down the empty streets, growing increasingly more annoyed.

Where was the backbone in these Humans? It seemed like all they were doing was squabbling with each other, not doing important things! Perhaps

that was why the Goblin army had come. They would easily kill the Humans.

Already the Goblin army outside the gates had been noticed. Toren saw many Humans abandon their camps and move into the city, afraid, fighting to get to a spot they considered safer. But that just meant they were fighting themselves again.

So stupid. Part of Toren missed the inn. Just a small part. He immediately quashed the thought when he had it, but wasn't it true? At least in the inn he had things to do. Here he was looking and he still couldn't find something worthwhile to kill. Whereas at the inn—

He could scrub the floors. And serve food. And that would level up his [Barmaid] class. It was...well, it wasn't as if Toren *liked* the class. But he liked leveling up. And here he had nothing much to do.

Toren was just considering going for broke and slaughtering everything he could when he heard the fighting. He turned, and saw a group of five men and two women, cornering a family. A man slashed at the other men with a short sword while he tried to guard his wife and two daughters. But the other men had clubs and sticks, and even if they weren't as sharp, there were a lot of them.

Perhaps it was the sword they were after. But Toren had a feeling the three females were also part of it. He was starting to figure out Human motivations, even if he didn't quite get the details.

Well, here was a fight. Perhaps Toren should join in—kill them all. The skeleton lifted his blade, ready to charge. But then he heard a shout. He saw someone run down the street, someone tall. In *armor*? Toren stepped back into a shadow as the men turned. He caught a glimpse of silver, flashing in the darkness. And then he saw the adventurer.

A tall man, blonde, wearing plate armor and holding a shield and sword that gleamed, charged down the snowy, dirty street. He was followed by three other adventurers, a man and two women Toren recognized. The [Fighter], the spear wielder, and the annoying mage! But these three were clearly different from the man in silver armor. Their equipment was cheap, if effective. But this man's armor *gleamed*.

And he moved faster than Toren would have guessed. In seconds he'd covered the distance between the thugs. He raised his sword as they turned, shouting in shock. Toren heard his voice, filled with outrage clearly across the street.

“You *scum!*”

He ran one man through and lopped the hand off of the other before the group of men could even blink. He turned, slashing, making the other Humans cry out in pain. The two women in the band of thugs weren’t spared from his wrath either. Within moments the entire group had fled. The only people that remained were the family that had been set upon.

“Are you alright?”

Toren heard the words as he stealthily made his way closer to the man in armor. He was standing, reassuring the tearful family as the other three adventurers stood behind him awkwardly. They hadn’t even gotten there in time to help!

“Bless you, sir. I don’t know what would have happened if you hadn’t come—”

The father was speaking to the adventurer. And yes, Toren was sure he was an adventurer. He had pouches at his belt, and he reminded Toren a lot of the Horns of Hammerad and Griffon Hunt.

“It was my duty. But you shouldn’t be out so late. Why haven’t you fled the city?”

“Where would we go, sir? There are Goblins on the road. And—they came back!”

The woman clutched at the Knight, speaking desperately and pointing. Toren knew she had to be talking about the Goblin army.

“We couldn’t leave. Going to another city after the Goblins attacked? In the cold, with nothing to eat or wear? We couldn’t. And then—we stayed. We thought we’d survive, but there are gangs roaming the streets, sir. We barely got away when the people we were with were attacked last time. And now...”

“I understand.”

The man’s voice was firm, quiet. He looked at the adventurers following him.

“You three. We’ll need to escort these good people to a safe place.”

“What?”

The Bronze-rank adventurers exclaimed in dismay. The man with the sword—whom Toren was displeased to note had healed the injuries the skeleton had given him—spoke to the adventurer in silver armor.

“Sir, we can’t just involve ourselves here! We should be leaving for another city! Take the family with us maybe, but those Goblins chased us

into the city! They'll probably attack at any moment!"

The man in armor glared at the [Fighter], but the woman with the spear piped up as well, looking nervous.

"But we can't leave! The Goblins have the road. And there's the skeleton we saw! The strange one! If we leave, we might run into it!"

"Fools. The dead are *rising*! Of course there are skeletons wandering the roads!"

The warrior in armor snapped at the others. They stopped, looking confused.

"What do you mean? Why are the dead rising?"

He stared at them incredulously. Toren was giving them much the same look from his hiding spot, in a small place where the cobblestones had been torn up to create a small depression. The man in silver armor sighed and spoke through gritted teeth.

"Rookies. Haven't you learned anything? Violence and anarchy in the street are but one of Esthelm's woes. This place was the site of a major battle where thousands died, both Goblins and Humans. You've seen the bodies. Don't you know what happens when they aren't properly buried or cremated?"

"They rise."

That came from the female [Mage]. She looked pale faced. The adventurer nodded.

"They rise. First zombies, then skeletons and even Ghouls if the slaughter is great enough. Given time, stronger undead will emerge as well. Crypt Lords...and far worse."

A groan of pure terror came from the family the man had saved. The father fell to his knees, beseeching.

"Mister Adventurer, sir! Can you not save us? If the undead rise—what chance do my family and I have?"

"Calm yourself. The issue of the undead is precisely the reason I came here."

The man in armor helped the father up, speaking reassuringly to the family.

"I am a Gold-rank adventurer. I heard of what had befallen Esthelm too late, but I set out as soon as I realized the other local cities were doing nothing to address the issue. The fools in the Adventurer's Guild were too afraid to venture out, even the Silver-ranked ones."

Toren's metaphorical ears perked up the instant he heard the adventurer mention his rank. Gold? Toren had seen Griffon Hunt and even the other team—the Halfseekers, but he'd never properly fought one before. The closest he'd come was fighting Halrac, and that had been completely one-sided.

But here...this adventurer was alone! Toren immediately wanted to challenge him, but he held off. Listen. Observe. He wriggled closer, moving slowly so as not to be seen. The Gold-rank adventurer was addressing everyone, his back turned to Toren.

"I came here to deal with the undead issue because no one else had the courage to make the journey. But instead I find a city's worth of people here, as well as a Goblin army?"

The man in silver armor paused. He shook his head.

"This all feels too connected. If what I suspect is true, the Goblins may have spared the people of this city for this moment. So many bodies, and so much potential for death—are they trying to create an undead horde to attack other cities with?"

"An undead horde? Could the Goblins really do such a thing?"

"Normal armies do it as well, I'm afraid, Miss. I'd like to say I could drive off the Goblins myself, but there are hundreds out there and I'm no Named Adventurer. Still, I think there's a way. If I can—"

He was so full of himself! So proud. So...why was Toren angry? But this seemed too easy. The skeleton was only a few feet away. He could use [Mirage Cut] and take the man down in seconds. Was this really a Gold-rank adventurer? How could one be so careless? But still, Toren would do it. He wanted the man's silver armor, not to mention his sword and shield.

Closer. Closer...Toren rose slowly, and moved at a crouch. None of them were looking at him! They all had their eyes on the armored man! Toren's hand was on his sword hilt. He didn't even have a scabbard. He could run the man through—

One of the daughters who'd been staring in horror and hope at the Gold-rank adventurer sneezed in the cold. She looked down for something to cover her nose, saw Toren. She screamed.

"Skeleton!"

The Gold-rank adventurer turned. He saw Toren and his eyes widened. His sword rose, but too late. The skeleton leapt at him, and his body *blurred*. His sword flashed out, but that was a decoy. Even if the adventurer

parried it, he'd still take the man's head. Who walked around in armor but didn't wear a helmet?

Idiot. Toren's sword scythed towards the man's head at lightning speed. [Mirage C—

“[Shield Breaker]!”

The shield pushed forwards, almost glowing. It filled Toren's vision, and then struck the skeleton like a house. The skeleton flew backwards, stumbling, nearly falling over. What happened? His Skill! How did—

The Gold-rank adventurer lowered his shield and stared at Toren, eyes narrowed.

“What manner of skeleton sneaks and hides? And uses a Skill?”

Toren readjusted his crooked head and grinned at the Gold-rank adventurer. He hadn't known someone could interrupt a Skill! His eyes flashed purple, and the Humans behind the adventurer screamed.

“Dead gods! It's back!”

“Run!”

The [Fear] effect made them all scatter at once. The man in armor called out, trying to slow them, but the others didn't listen. They ran, leaving the adventurer behind.

Perfect. Toren charged at the man as he turned and shouted. The skeleton brought the blade down two-handed in a vertical slash that should have split the man's head open. But the blade *twisted* in the air a foot away from the man's head. It curved left and Toren missed completely, striking the man's armored shoulder!

What was that? Magic? It had to be. Toren gaped and then a sword pierced his ribcage effortlessly.

“Hmf. A spell-like effect? You aren't a normal undead monster, are you?”

The Gold-rank adventurer cut sideways, and Toren staggered as several ribs on his left side were torn away. But that was just a few bones! He cut again, but this time his sword bounced off the silvery shield, not even scratching the metal.

“A revenant? Or some kind of Goblin creation? Either way—begone.”

Now the man in silver armor charged forwards, his shield ramming into Toren. The skeleton tried to stand his ground, but he was thrown by the incredible force behind the adventurer's shield. He hit the ground, rolled, trying to get up—

A sword lopped the top off of his head. Toren collapsed, his bones rolling on the ground. The Gold-rank adventurer stared down at him, murmuring to himself.

“Nothing about this makes sense. A skeleton that can think? No—the Necromancer? But why would he use such an inferior creation?”

Inferior? If Toren could have said anything—or moved—he would have been indignant. But he lay on the ground, waiting for the adventurer to leave before he reassembled himself. He was clearly not as strong as that warrior, either in experience or strength.

“One more question to ask later. Damn. Where did the others run off to? Well before that—I should dispose of the remains.”

So saying, the adventurer reached towards his belt pouch. Immediately, Toren began to panic.

Dispose of him? What was that? He—that wasn’t fair! No one was supposed to care about Toren after a fight! That was his specialty. If the adventurer was going to destroy him—

From the ground, the skeleton could only stare helplessly as the man reached into his pouch. But before the Gold-rank adventurer could take whatever was in there out, the skeleton heard pounding footsteps. The man in silver armor turned—

And nearly caught a blow to the head from a club. At the last moment the piece of wood swerved, just as it had done with Toren. But the blow still knocked the off-guard adventurer down.

“What the—?”

He rose, shield up, but another man struck him from behind. Toren gaped as he saw more men swarm the Gold-rank adventurer, beating at him with clubs, kicking, trying to pin him down—

It was a gang! And they were trying to kill the adventurer! Toren had never been more grateful to petty Humans in his life. He heard the man shout, and then saw the press of bodies fly backwards. Several stumbled back, and the man in armor was on his feet, swinging his sword and shield to keep them at bay.

“*Cowards!* Are you insane? I’ve come here to—”

He got no further. Stones, and even an arrow flew at his head. Men with slings aiming at his head! Again the missiles flew askew, but whatever magic was protecting the man’s head was clearly weakening. He snarled, deflected a stone aimed at his jaw—

And staggered, as a club smashed into his head from behind. Toren saw the man pull back and hit the adventurer in the same spot again, with all his might.

It was a powerful blow. But the man in silver armor didn't fall. He stumbled forwards, but he refused to kneel or drop. Instead, his shield came up, hitting the man who'd struck him so hard he gasped and stumbled back.

"Fool."

It was one word, but it was louder than the shouting of the gang as they tried to close in. A man ran at the knight—a sword came up even with the man's head still bowed. It ran the man through.

"*Fools!*"

The gang stopped. The sword left the man's chest and he collapsed, dead. The knight turned. A stone flew at his head and his shield snapped up. He deflected the stone *back* at the man who'd loosed it from his sling. The rock hit the man and there was a cry of pain.

Now the Gold-rank adventurer finally looked up. He raised his head slowly, the tendons in his neck straining. Blood ran and matted in his hair, but he turned and stared down the man who'd struck him. The sword shone bright and silver and crimson in his hands, but the adventurer didn't raise his weapon.

"What are you doing, you *idiot?*"

The thug he addressed stepped back, eyes wide. The man in silver armor turned towards him, and the man raised his club defensively. But one armored hand shot out and tore the weapon out of the other man's grip.

"No—"

Flinching, the man raised his hands, prepared for death. But the adventurer just hurled the club to the ground. He stared at the other men who'd ambushed him. Fury burned in his voice as he shouted at them.

"Is this what you are? You—you, the men of Esthelm! I came here to this burned city to put your dead to rest. But what do I find? Men, preying on each other like vermin! Have you no *shame?* Where's your pride? Where is your honor?"

He turned around to the stunned group, armor glinting as he stared each one of them in the eye. The Gold-rank adventurer didn't even seem to notice their arms—rather, it was as if he didn't even care that he was outnumbered.

“There are women and children—people who suffer and need help! Your friends and family cry out in this city, but what do you do? The instant your walls fall you turn on them. Shame.”

The word touched the hearts of his listeners. It made them feel ashamed, and angry and guilty as well. Perhaps they would have rushed him, but the man in armor was too imposing. And his words struck at their hearts, the hearts they’d closed in despair.

The man wearing silver looked around in disgust. He lowered his sword—and to the astonishment of the other men, sheathed it. He walked towards several men. They raised their weapons, but he just stopped and glanced at them, still full of that barely restrained passion.

“Lower your weapons and follow me if you want to save this city, you fools.”

They hesitated. Two hands shot out and tore the makeshift weapons and poor swords from their grip. The Gold-ranked adventurer stared down at the other men and raised his voice.

“I am Ylawes Byres, a [Knight]. I am a Gold-rank adventurer and I can save this city. But I cannot do it alone. If you still believe in Esthelm—follow my back.”

He strode down the broken streets, not looking back. The men hesitated. Some lowered their weapons and turned to go. But the man who had struck Ylawes picked up his club. He hung it at his belt and ran after the adventurer.

More men followed him. They joined the Gold-rank adventurer, and he snapped at them as if he’d never doubted they’d be there.

“Come on. There’s still time to do what’s right.”

The man’s footsteps faded away. The majority of the men followed him, while the others slipped away. After a few minutes, a pile of bones reassembled itself in the snow. Toren stood up, grabbed his sword, and stared in the direction the man named Ylawes had gone.

Now what was all *that* about?

The monster waited, hungry. She was always hungry. Her story was one of despair and all-consuming desire. To eat. To feed.

She saw a thing crawl out of the sewers. A dead woman, corpse bloated and rotten. She told herself she didn't want to eat it. But she did. Oh yes, she did.

The zombie shambled down the street. The monster who looked vaguely like a young Human woman followed her. The zombie moved quickly—stumbling, searching out food. It never noticed her.

And it found prey. A young man slept in the hollowed-out building that might have been his home. He would have been safe, hidden from most Humans. But not from a zombie. It found him as it wandered in, and fell upon him.

The monster heard the screams, and part of her told her to act. It wasn't hard. She simply gave into her desires.

The zombie was biting and clawing at the young man on the ground. He was trying to fend her off, but he was barely awake, and weak with hunger. And the dead woman had far more strength than he did. She was biting at him—tearing at his flesh.

Just like she wanted to do. But the girl that was a monster focused on the zombie instead. Yes. Hungry. The gray, rotted flesh called to her.

For once she didn't fight the urge. She wanted to eat. The monster girl walked behind the zombie and seized the dead woman. The undead turned, reaching out to kill, to steal life—

Did it hesitate? It stared into a gaping maw. The monster girl's mouth. Her jaws opened wide—impossibly wide—and she felt her jaw dangling far lower than it should. But it just meant she could *bite* more.

She bit the zombie's face. She tore away rotted flesh easily, teeth scissoring through skin like parchment. The zombie made a sound—tried to tear at her body. But the girl had a monster's body now. An Eater's form. Her skin was tough, and the sharp fingernails and bruising strength did little to her.

She bit again. Now she bit into bone, and something which *oozed*. Part of the former [Florist] wanted to scream. But the zombie was danger. To the boy—

She realized he was still there as she knelt on the ground, savaging the dead zombie's form. The girl turned her head towards him. He was wide-eyed, pale with horror as he stared at her.

For a moment she wanted to say something. But though she opened her mouth, no words came out. And he—he looked into her eyes and saw only

a horror. A monster.

“Get—get away!”

The young man she’d saved struck her in the face, in the chest, kicking her backwards. The girl looked at him, the monster salivated. She wanted to eat him.

But she couldn’t. That much she held onto. And now he was pulling out a dagger, holding it in his bleeding hands. Danger.

So she fled. She fled into the street, crying. She could still cry. She ran down an alleyway, and into a small open space. And then she saw it.

The skeleton. He was walking down the street, slashing at the air angrily with a sword. He was all bones—little to eat. She stopped when she saw him, feeling afraid for some reason. His purple eyes found her, and the girl inside the beast shuddered in panic. She turned to run—

But he stabbed her from behind.

The Goblin warriors heard the girl scream. And they saw the skeleton stabbing at her, because they’d been following her for the last block.

It had just been a chance encounter. But as the Goblins had moved silently through the streets, searching for bodies that weren’t completely rotted, they’d come across a fortuitous find. A gang of four men had been pilfering a box with some spices inside. Naturally, the Goblins had fallen on them at once. An arrow to the back, two blades stabbing. Grunter just pushed one of the men’s heads into a wall, killing him.

They didn’t mind killing Humans. It was just that they didn’t do it needlessly. Food was a definite need, though. So the Goblins had been lugging their find back to the small base they’d set up in a ruined building when they’d seen the girl.

She’d stood out. Not because of her ragged clothing, or thin body—all the Humans more or less looked like that in the city. But she was clearly different from the other Humans.

Her face was different. No, not just her face, her very body. It was as if someone had taken a bit of monster, a bit of savage primal humanity and something darker, and put it into her body. And the way she moved! She moved around hunched, or on all fours, more like an animal or stalking thing than a Human.

It had stood out. Badarrow had pointed the girl out and the Goblins had watched her, as a potential threat more than anything else. But then they'd seen the girl find a body in the snow.

It was rotted, a Human's body, some warrior who'd died in the battle for Esthelm. Even the other Goblins had turned their noses up at it—they preferred fresh dead meat, thank you. But the girl had dug it up—and then begun to eat it!

That had stopped the Redfang warriors in their tracks. For a moment they hadn't believed what they were seeing. A Human? Eating a dead body?

Well, yes. Humans did that all the time. With animals, of course, as if that made a difference. But this young woman was eating another Human!

That wasn't shocking to the Goblins, at least in a basic sense. They ate Humans all the time. It was just survival. But as far as they knew, other Humans never ate each other—or even other species, for that matter!

It made her stand out, and because they were curious, the Goblins had followed her a bit longer. They were adept at keeping to shadows, so they'd seen the zombie crawl out of the sewers and the way the girl had stalked it.

Yes, stalked it. They could tell the signs. And then they'd seen her rescue the young Human man, and run from him.

How strange. How curious! And—how disturbing.

Again, not the Human girl, or whatever strange thing she actually was. It was the zombie that made Grunter grunt in alarm and Headscratcher eye the sewers.

The undead. How could the Goblins have forgotten them? If they were rising—

It was bad news. Very bad. The Goblins had no desire to fight off a horde of zombies, much less the stronger undead that would rise with so many bodies around. They were about to retreat and reconsider their hiding spot—they'd need to create traps and barricades if the undead were about—when they heard the girl scream.

That was when they saw the skeleton. It had encountered the girl on the street, a skeleton with a sword. And when she'd turned to flee, the skeleton had stabbed her in the back!

It wasn't a deep wound, but the Goblins saw the skeleton cutting at the girl's legs, trying to cripple her. She was trying to flee, and perhaps she would succeed. She was quick—quicker than a normal Human. And her

skin was tough enough that the skeleton's slightly dulled blade couldn't cut her that deep.

The Goblins watched, sitting on a rooftop that had remained after the fire. The girl slashed at the skeleton with her claws, snarling desperately. Badarrow nudged Rabbiteater and pointed. The Goblins looked and saw she had strangely long fingers and nails that were more like claws on the ends of them. And from the way they cut into the skeleton's bone, they were clearly sharp as steel!

What *was* this strange Human? Was she some kind of...of half-breed? There were Goblins who'd been born of Humans of course, so the idea wasn't new to the Goblins, but this?

The Goblins had never heard of a Human like this. Perhaps it was all some Skill? They knew some Drakes and Gnolls fought with their claws and could get Skills like this. But a Human?

And her jaw! Headscratcher blinked as the monster girl tried to take a bite out of the skeleton. He dodged back, and her gaping mouth caught only air. Even the Goblins thought that looked creepy, the way she could make her jaw open so wide.

The skeleton tried to stab her in the stomach, but the girl smacked his sword away. It was a lucky blow; she clearly hadn't expected to be able to, but she was strong. Strong, fast, ravenous...

"Ghoul."

That was what Grunter muttered. The others looked at him, and then nodded in agreement.

She was *exactly* like a Ghoul, one of the ravenous undead that fought in bursts of frenzied movement. And yet, she was more than a Ghoul. She was still alive, and she had a keen intelligence about her that Ghouls lacked. But for all that—

The skeleton was stronger. Not just stronger—he was fighting smart. When he lost his sword, the skeleton crouched and kicked out. The girl stumbled, and then the undead tackled her, knocking her to the ground. She cried out, trying to throw it off her, but the skeleton was on top of her. He punched her in the face, repeatedly, hammering his fist into her head as she cried out in pain and fear.

He was going to bash her brains out. The Goblins watched, some turning away now the fight was over. They wouldn't interfere in a fight like

this. It wasn't like the Human boy—here were two killers, killing each other. It was just life.

They turned to go, but a faint sound stopped them. Sitting closest to the scene on his part of the roof, Headscratcher made a quizzical noise. They looked at him, and he scratched his head slowly, before pointing at the skeleton.

Skeleton. Yes, it was a skeleton. The Redfang warriors stared at Headscratcher blankly. Where was he going with this?

Slowly, the finger shifted to the girl.

Girl. Or rather, young woman.

They stared at her. A young Human woman. Something about the way they thought that bugged them.

A young Human woman? An [Innkeeper].

Everyone stared at Headscratcher. No. It couldn't be it. But he pointed insistently at the skeleton. And the other Goblins stared at it, suddenly connecting the dots.

A skeleton. Hadn't Garen Redfang mentioned something about a skeleton? Yes, he'd said it was pulling the [Innkeeper] on a sleigh!

It was highly unusual to see a skeleton here, even in this city where the dead were rising. Even if the dead rose—they'd be zombies and ghouls, not skeletons. They hadn't nearly enough time to rot to that extent. So why was a skeleton *here*?

The Goblins stared at each other. Here was a Human girl. And a skeleton. And Esthelm had been a city full of inns, hadn't it?

Then again, the skeleton was trying to beat the girl to death. Even as the Goblins watched, the skeleton drew a bloody fist back. He was pounding the girl's head into the broken ground, drawing blood. She was making a whimpering sound, not even fighting back.

Something stirred in the Goblins' chests. But they were still reluctant to act. So what if she died? Their job had been to kill her, after all.

Headscratcher nodded, but then shook his head to this obvious conclusion. He pointed down at the girl and skeleton, raising a thumb.

Skeleton and girl. This might actually be the girl they'd come to kill. But—he shook his head—they wouldn't kill her because they'd decided. He pointed to the skeleton. He would, though. And that was the problem.

The Goblins stared at Headscratcher, confused. The Goblin tried to explain his line of thought. Garen had ordered them to kill the girl, yes?

And if she died, even if the skeleton killed her instead of them, he'd be happy, right?

But they'd decided not to obey Garen! He *shouldn't* be obeyed! So—and here Headscratcher's silent gesturing really got complex—if they were obeying Rags instead of Garen, wouldn't that mean they would want to protect the [Innkeeper]? At the very least, letting her die was probably as bad as killing her themselves, and if Rags didn't want that...

The Goblins stared at each other, brains aching with thought. Headscratcher just looked at them, looked at the girl.

They could hear her sobbing. It was a sound that bothered them. They'd heard Humans cry, but this—

Perhaps it was because she ate the dead. Like them. She was doing anything she could to survive. Like them. The skeleton was hitting her, gleefully.

Headscratcher stared at the other reluctant warriors. Then he made a decision. He stood up, unsheathed his sword. He leapt from the rooftop.

After a moment, twelve Goblins followed him.

Toren saw the first Goblin land on the ground. He stopped punching the strange not-Human he'd found in surprise. The Goblin had a sword in his hand, and he was snarling at Toren.

A Goblin? Had they already begun to attack? Well then, why was Toren wasting time here? He jumped away from the young woman, letting her lie half-dead. He scrambled for his sword, lifting it with a grin.

One Goblin was no threat. He charged at the Goblin and locked blades, forcing the Goblin back a step. But to his surprise, the Goblin threw Toren backwards after a moment of struggle. He was *strong*! Stronger than a Goblin should be!

That made Toren angry. What was with strong warriors popping up all over the place? A Gold-rank adventurer he could respect, but a *Goblin*?

He was about to hack at the Goblin when another Goblin landed on the ground next to him. A Goblin with a bow. He drew and loosed an arrow at Toren's skull in an instant. The skeleton dodged reflexively, and the arrow flew past him.

Two Goblins. Okay, they might be a bit stronger than usual, but—

Five more Goblins landed next to them. The flames in Toren's eyes dimmed as he saw they all wore armor and moved to surround him.

Where were all these Goblins *coming* from? Struck by a thought, Toren looked up. He saw a huge, fat foot descending towards his face—

Grunter *smashed* the skeleton into the ground, landing heavily and grunting in his trademark fashion as he did. He kicked the skull several feet away dismissively, and stared at the girl.

She was curled up into a small ball of misery and pain. She was still sobbing, not even realizing she'd been saved. There was only pain and her, waiting for death.

Too familiar. Grunter looked away and grunted. The sound made the girl look up.

She stared at the Goblins and made a choked, screaming sound when she saw them. She tried to get away, but her legs still weren't working. But the Goblins didn't attack her. They just stared at her, and then went into a huddle.

For the Redfang warriors, they were suddenly faced with a conundrum after saving the girl and killing the skeleton. Okay, they'd saved her, and if she was the [Innkeeper], they'd probably done a good thing that Rags would approve of, right?

Right. But what did they do next? All eyes turned to Headscratcher. He just scratched his head, unsure.

The Goblins stared at the girl. She was crouched warily on the ground, staring at them with huge eyes. They returned to their huddle.

They could probably just leave her, right? After all, what else could they do? She was safe—they'd done what was probably the right thing. Now it was time to go back and eat.

Undead in the city. Badarrow grunted as he retrieved his missed arrow. The girl stared at him as he passed—he eyed her. The Goblins turned to go. The girl stared at them. Her stare bothered the Goblins more than they could really say.

Goblins? They'd saved her. Why?

The monster didn't know. But the Goblins *had* saved her, and they weren't going to attack her or—or do worse. She'd been afraid of that for a moment, but the Goblin with the bow had just walked past her without even looking right at her.

Now they seemed to be leaving. The Goblins slowly walked away.

Leaving her behind. Even Goblins didn't want to associate with a monster.

Hot wetness blinded the horror for a second. She could still taste the rotting flesh in her mouth, still see the horror in the young man's eyes. She was a monster. No—worse than that.

She looked at the backs of the retreating Goblin warriors. Goblins. They were monsters, too. They'd saved her. Because she was a monster like them?

The Goblins had destroyed Esthelm. They were horrible, pillaging, raping creatures who killed any Human they came across. They were true monsters.

But so was she.

And she was alone. And if they killed her—

Slowly, the girl got up. Her face burned and she had trouble breathing from where the skeleton had tried to crush her windpipe. She stared at the backs of monsters, short, green creatures that walked like men.

Monsters.

She followed them.

When Toren reassembled this time he was ready to kill everything in the world. He got up and then ran around, hitting everything in sight.

Goblins! He'd been defeated by—by *Goblins!* And it hadn't even been like last time! Last time he'd been outnumbered but this time—

One had landed on him! The indignity of it made Toren so angry he felt like he could have exploded. He was filled with all-consuming rage.

And fear. A bit of fear was in Toren as well. For the first time, he sensed danger.

Not because of the Goblins. Damn the Goblins! He could kill them if he had time to plan things out, he was sure. But Toren felt the mana in his body

running dangerously low.

Erin supplied him with energy, of course. He knew that. Normally it was enough for everything he did, even though she wasn't exactly a font of magic. But after so many repeated deaths and reassemblies, he realized he was on the verge of running out.

If he was scattered one more time, if his pieces were separated—Toren feared the animation spell that gave him life might end for good. He couldn't let that happen.

He couldn't...*die*.

No problem, then! Toren would just find somewhere to wait while he regained a bit more mana. An hour would be enough. All he had to do was get his sword and...and...

Toren looked for his sword. He'd dropped over there? Over here? He paused, and then did a slow circle.

No. It couldn't be. It was impossible!

He'd lost his sword! Toren searched for it frantically in the snow, trying not to believe it was true. But it was.

His sword was gone.

Had one of the Goblins taken it? Or the monster-girl?

Maybe. All Toren knew was that he was suddenly defenseless. Of course, he could fight with his hands and feet, but that wasn't the same as having a weapon. His Skills were designed for a weapon—without one, Toren did feel vulnerable.

And he couldn't die.

The skeleton felt a chill in his bones. He stared around the open area, suddenly realizing how vulnerable he was. If one of the Goblins came back, or even the girl-thing—

He couldn't risk it. The skeleton hesitated, then swiftly ran down an alley.

He had to find shelter. A hiding spot. Could he squeeze himself into a small space? What about a weapon? Could he take one from a Human? But what if they got lucky and killed him?

Toren had never been so afraid. He ran, pausing at every shadow, trying to find somewhere totally secluded. He spotted an opening in the ground—a dark entrance and dove towards it.

The sewers! Toren immediately recognized the foul, dark tunnels and relaxed. No one would come down here! Not even Goblins liked this much

filth. He could rest here, wait a while. And then—

The skeleton had let his guard down too early. As he walked further into the sewers, his foot caught on a floating body. It moved, and then jerked to life.

A corpse, dead, eyes glowing with yellow light, sprang up. Toren jerked back, and then realized one of the dead had risen. Oh. Was that all? It had surprised him, but it was just a zombie. Toren backed away in case the undead started flailing about—

The dead body sprang at Toren, making a gurgling *snarling* sound. Toren jerked in shock, and the corpse bore him into the slime of the sewers.

Not a zombie! A *Ghoul*! More bodies were rising around Toren, actual zombies this time. But the ghoul had focused on Toren and identified him as a threat. It tore at the skeleton, trying to rip his bones away—

Trying to kill him.

Fear suddenly gripped Toren. He clenched his bony fists and began hammering at the Ghoul, trying to knock it off him, break its skull. But it was freshly dead and still relatively intact. And it had him on the ground! It was tearing away Toren's ribs, one at a time!

So strong! It—Toren was going to die! It was stronger than Toren, and tougher too in this moment. He felt so weak.

He was going to die.

No! Toren plunged a finger into the Ghoul's eye socket, piercing the rotted eyeball. But the Ghoul felt no pain and didn't need eyes to see. Toren punched the corpse repeatedly, but nothing was working.

He was going to die! The Ghoul was going to kill him! It was impossible! Unacceptable! He couldn't die like this!

Not like this! Toren raged silently as he tried to force the Ghoul off of him. Not like this! Not to a Ghoul! If he had time—a bit more time to regain mana!

Someone, anyone! Toren cried out. He needed help! He needed assistance! Anyone, the adventurer, the Humans with clubs, the monster girl, the Goblins—

The ghoul was reaching for his head, twisting it. It would all be over. Toren fought it, trying to hold the arms back. So weak. Someone. Please help.

Erin—

A hand dragged the Ghoul off of Toren. The skeleton saw the Ghoul jerk, turn—another hand smashed into the back of its head.

Erin?

For a second the skeleton thought—but when he stood up, he saw only zombies.

Zombies?

Yes, the undead corpses were surrounding the Ghoul! In disbelief, Toren saw the Ghoul fighting them, tearing at their faces, trying to bear them to the ground—but six zombies were all striking it, tearing it apart, eating its flesh—

The zombies had helped Toren. That was what the skeleton realized after the shock had worn off. He sat in the filth of the sewer as the zombies finished destroying the Ghoul, leaving the chewed limbs floating in the water.

How? And why? All Toren knew was that he'd cried out for help. He'd reached out—

And the zombies had answered. These, the lowliest of the undead had come to his aid. Why? Because he was a skeleton and they were like him? Because they hated ghouls?

No, that was silly. It was because—

Toren touched the flames in his skull. His eyes? Skinner had commanded the dead. Was it that? Something else? Some secret to his creation?

The skeleton didn't know. But the zombies stopped, swaying in front of him. They were waiting for his command.

The skeleton stared at them in shock. And then he heard the voice, echoing in his head. He hadn't heard it for a while, but now it came into his mind, sharp and clear, and oh so welcome.

[Leader Class Obtained!]

[Leader Level 1!]

[Skill – Command Lesser Undead obtained!]

For a few moments, Toren's head was filled with clouds. He stood in the sewer, poleaxed by the revelation. But when he came back to himself, he just stared at the zombies.

Six zombies. Waiting for his command. And now Toren felt certain he *could* command them. In fact, if he wanted to...

Well now. Wasn't *this* interesting?

This is the story of a skeleton. He stood in the dark sewers of a city full of death, where a Human with silver armor tried to save the living and a monster followed a band of Goblin warriors. The skeleton had travelled far, had thrown off his shackles and come here.

He had been humbled. He had nearly died. But he had survived. He had survived and he would still survive, growing stronger. That was what he pledged to himself. He would survive.

And he was no longer alone.

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3.19 T

Esthelm. City of the damned and dead. That was how it felt sometimes. Of course, there were thousands of people still living inside of it, but for many, their miserable, desperate existence was just a prelude to death and worse. Their home was in ruins, and their city was slowly filling with the undead. It was undeniable, now.

They came out of the sewers. They sat up in the cold snow. They dug themselves out of the frozen ground and from beneath the rubble.

They rose.

Not just one, not just two—hundreds. Hundreds. Zombies, yes, but ghouls as well. They came for the living, and without trained warriors, the refugees of Esthelm could not hope to defend themselves from such a horde.

If they could, they would have fled. Even the cold, merciless winter night was better than death and undeath. But they could not.

An army of Goblins camped outside the city. Already, a score of people had died as they'd tried to leave the city and been set on. The Goblins maintained a perimeter, laughing, shooting arrows at any Human they saw. And more were coming. Already the people could see Goblin warriors wearing black armor gathering into teams, preparing to sweep into the city.

Goblins outside, undead within. And disunity and chaos among them. The Humans despaired and some simply waited for death while others took what small satisfaction they could, giving into cruelty and lust before the end. After all, who would save them?

The answer came during the darkest hours of the night, when some huddled behind the flimsy walls they'd built and others went searching for victims. They heard a voice, and saw silver.

A man in plate armor. An adventurer with a sword and shield. No, no ordinary adventurer—a Gold-rank one! A [Knight].

He strode into one camp and raised his voice.

“Citizens of Esthelm! Hear my words!”

No one had called them that, or thought of them like that since the city had fallen. People, disbelieving, crept out to watch him and saw the men at

his back. Men and women. And children. Hundreds, already close to a thousand.

“Esthelm has fallen. But you still remain! The undead rise and must be stopped. A Goblin army has come to kill whomever remains in this city. If you keep fighting among yourselves, you will die! But together we may yet live.”

That was all he said. But the people saw him bring his hundreds into the camp, and begin building. He had more rubble removed, had people with Skills—people who’d almost forgotten their Classes—begin to build.

He had them build a wall. Not around a small plot of land to hide in, as the others had done, but massive barricades, linking half-fallen buildings and sealing off entire streets. He was building fortifications, sealing off nearly a quarter of the city and setting guards, men and women with weapons and hope in their eyes to fend off the undead.

He was retaking their home. And so people came forward, at first the desperate, but then everyone, abandoning the places they’d carved out, coming, some fearful, others ashamed, but coming nevertheless.

Coming home. And so the Humans built desperately, and gathered arms, and the Gold-rank adventurer walked among them, tirelessly coordinating them, giving them courage.

Ylawes Byres. He stared towards the edge of the city, where the Goblins were waiting. He’d chosen a spot as far away from them as possible. It would be war soon, he knew. A last war, a final war for this city. Whether it would mean death and ruin for a place already rotten and torn apart or a new spark of life for this place he did not know. He only knew he would make the Goblins pay in blood for every step they took.

However, this was not his story. Instead, the city’s fate belonged in no small part to another being. A skeleton, a creature of death, common and worthless among the endless undead. Yet this one was unlike any other skeleton in the world. He danced in the dying city, as the snow began to fall.

A shadow shivered and twisted amidst the center of the city. A shadow with eyes that burned purple and bright even in the darkest night. Shapes

moved and walked among the empty buildings, crawling, creeping, seeking out the light to snuff it out.

But the shadow danced on. Death and corruptions swirled through the streets, standing up, taking awful forms and biting, chewing. But the shadow danced, and it had a name.

Toren.

He whirled about in the street, arms spread wide. His was not some demonic summoning, nor the wild and sinister movements of ritual and sin. Instead, the skeleton ran about, twirling and doing handstands and waving his arms about, full of innocent mirth. He danced like a child, delighted, simple. He had a new toy! Not just one in fact. He had a world full of them!

He could control the undead! How wonderful was that?

Toren stopped whirling about and turned to look at some of the shadows around him. Six swaying corpses stared at him, barely noticeable as they stood in the shadows. They had been men and women, but now rot and decay had turned them into something else.

Zombies. Pathetic fodder any warrior could kill individually, only fearsome in vast numbers, and even then, only to the unprepared. But they were *his*. His.

He could control them. Toren knew it. He felt the certainty in his mind and saw it when he ordered the zombies to follow him. He walked down the street as they followed in his wake.

This changed everything. Toren had been about to die, and they had saved him. And now—

What should he do now? Toren glanced at one of the zombies and it stopped. He slowly made it walk in front of him, and inspected the zombie carefully.

Yup. Dead. And a worm was crawling around in its exposed brain. Toren pulled it out and patted the zombie on its squishy head. His zombie.

Of course, he could always get a new one. But for now, Toren was curious. What could it do? He made the zombie walk back and forth in front of him, hit the zombie standing next to it, lie down...

Interesting. He *couldn't* tell the zombie to do very specific things. For instance, Toren had tried to get the zombie to hop on one leg and it hadn't moved. Because he was too low level? All he could get it to do was move and attack what he wanted.

That was too bad. But then again, it was still an excellent start. Toren rubbed his hands together, grinning.

Zombies. Just imagine what he could do with them! He'd no longer be alone in a fight—he wouldn't even have to fight if he didn't want to.

True, this didn't mean he could suddenly challenge Griffon Hunt or even the Gold-rank adventurer who'd beaten him once. Toren knew that. Right now he could control six undead. And only zombies to boot. But if he leveled? What then?

The possibilities sent shivers down the skeleton's spine. Where could he begin? How would he level up?

By leading his minions, obviously. Toren cast around, and then had another idea. He was still a bit low on mana. He could probably pull himself back together once if he was broken, but he didn't want to risk anything.

So why not stop fighting himself and instead have some fun? His zombies might be mindless, but they could certainly help out Toren in their limited way. To start with for example...

A sword. Toren wanted one. His zombies lurched towards a camp of Humans he'd seen earlier that day. They were a group of men who'd hunkered down in an alleyway, putting up flimsy barricades and trash barriers to keep other people away.

The zombies came to the alleyway and paused. They turned into it, walking, stumbling forwards. Perched on a crumbling rooftop, Toren watched as one of the men on guard duty shouted out in alarm as he saw the zombies.

Within moments, the other men—who'd been sleeping in clumsy sleeping bags made of whatever fabric they could get their hands on around the smoldering fire—were on their feet. They grasped weapons in their hands, clubs, slings, and, Toren was pleased to note, an iron short sword held by a big man that looked like their leader.

The gang of men was clearly arguing as the zombies slowly broke down the wooden planks that had been nailed together to form an obstacle and then slowly came down the alley towards them. Half of them wanted to leave, but their leader pointed out the obvious. There were six zombies, and they were eight strong! Plus, the zombies were slow, clumsy—their slinger whirled a stone that took the eye out of one. The other men began throwing things, and the zombies stumbled and one fell, struggling to get up.

Stupid, foolish undead. They'd never get close enough at their meandering pace. The men laughed and shouted triumphantly as they began to batter the zombies with missiles. From his seat above, Toren laughed and gave his zombies one order.

The foremost zombie had been stumbling backwards, flesh torn and bones fractured from the stones that kept smashing into his skull. Bits of brain were already leaking from his open skull. The man throwing stones stood confidently ahead of the others, picking up rocks from a pile at his feet as he confidently loosed stones at the zombies. He was close to them, but so what? It wasn't as if they could move—

The zombie took a step, and then *charged* down the alleyway. The man with the sling screamed in horror and turned to run. But too late—the zombie tackled him, and then he was tearing at the man as he tried to fight the creature off with his hands, biting at his throat—ripping away red flesh —

The gang of men had frozen in horror. Half of them ran forwards to help their friend, but then they decided he was dead and tried to run. Again, too late.

The other zombies ran at them, not sluggishly lurching as they'd done before, but *sprinting*, moving with inhuman speed that cared nothing for torn muscle or the broken ground. The men raised their weapons, but found they were of little use. Clubs that could break bones and spiked bats that could tear flesh did not scare those already dead.

The leader of the gang backed up. His sword at least could chop, but he was no [Swordsman], or even a [Warrior]. He hacked at the zombies killing the screaming men in his gang, hitting his comrades as often as the zombies. And when the zombies dropped the dead men to the ground, the man with the short sword found himself alone.

He turned to run. But the zombies were quick.

Sitting on the rooftop, Toren grinned as the zombies finished killing the leader. Only three were left; the man with the sword had gotten one, and two more had been killed in the fight. But so what? He knew there were countless zombies in the city.

And he'd come up with another excellent discovery for his trouble. The zombies had taken out the men so easily, and with just one order from him. A simple one, really. He didn't know why he hadn't thought of it instantly.

Run. That was all he'd told them to do. Just...run. And so they'd ran.

Why didn't zombies do it all the time? Toren realized that maybe some did—he hadn't exactly even seen that many zombies before today. Just when Skinner had attacked Erin's inn, really. And in the crypt.

Zombies were weak. True. They were slow and they rotted easily and they had no concept of dodging, blocking, or even retreating. But what if you could make them run? Then you had an entirely different kind of monster on your hands. Because yes, zombies were simple fighters, but they were still *strong*. And they didn't fear injury.

Toren clattered his jaw excitedly. He could already sense that this little skirmish had helped him get closer to a level up. In a moment he'd go down and get his new sword. And then—

Well, he had zombies, didn't he? And there were many more groups of thugs, just waiting for the day so they could begin marauding again. Perfect prey, in short. Could Toren wipe out an even bigger gang with six zombies? Could he do it without losing even one?

This was a challenge. A *fun* challenge. Toren leapt from his rooftop and landed in the snow, where his undead servants were waiting for him. He looked into their lifeless eyes, their empty sockets, and grinned. He smiled, and in his eyes, Esthelm burned.

This is the story of a monster. This is the story of a girl. At least, she'd been a girl, a Human once.

Now she didn't know what she was.

She had no name. Or rather, she'd forgotten it. It, like all her words, was gone. Only hunger remained. Hunger, and despair.

And fear. That was the real irony of it all, wasn't it? That even now, even when she'd lost everything, her family, home, levels—even humanity—even now, she was afraid of dying.

She'd nearly died. The skeleton she'd encountered had tried to kill her. He'd pounded at her, trying to kill her. And she'd wept, because she would finally die and be free of the nightmare.

But she hadn't *wanted* to die. She'd still wanted to live, even then. She'd nearly given up hope, though, resigned herself to death.

That's when they'd saved her. The Goblins. They'd come and killed the skeleton. She'd thought they just wanted to kill and eat her themselves, or

do worse, but they hadn't. They'd looked at her and left.

So why had she followed them? The monster paused as she loped on all fours after them. The snow and stone were cold on her skin, but her new body could withstand far more than her old one. Even now, the beating the skeleton had given her was healing.

But the Goblins? Why pursue them? She didn't know. But they were monsters. So maybe she deserved their company. And she had nothing else, so why not? Death would be a welcome thing if it came to that.

At any rate, the Goblins weren't chasing her off. The girl in the monster saw the warriors glancing back at her as they marched through the empty streets now and then, but none of them tried to chase her off. Rather, it looked like they were chattering amongst themselves as they looked at her.

Could Goblins talk? Maybe in their own language. The monster didn't know. But she was surprised by the idea. And when she saw the place the Goblins had chosen to camp for the night—

Her jaw dropped in surprise. The Goblins had set up in the center of a building that had been hollowed out by fire. But instead of squatting in the ashes and ruins like beasts, they'd cleared away the soot and snow, revealing bare stone. They'd taken bits of wood and covered the windows and doors, and even built a fire pit in the center of the building!

Now two of the Goblins sat around the fire pit, one piling kindling together and shaving bits of wood as the other struck sparks. A small fragment of wood caught, and the Goblins put their hands around the small flame, shielding it as it ate the kindling and grew.

Within a few minutes they had a fire. The monster sat on her haunches on the edge of the building, afraid to go in. But the warriors took no notice of her, and so she dared enter the camp. She stared around with wide eyes, drinking in...

Civilization. It was such an odd word, but that was what she saw. The warriors were making a fire. And what were they doing now? The Goblins were...putting their beds together! They had beds?

Yes, some of the Goblins had blankets in their possessions. Others had only the clothing they wore—one had a small stuffed pillow of all things, just large enough to cushion his head! They spread out their gear—weapons, bows and arrows—around them, forming small nests close to but not too near the fire. Places to sleep, places of their own.

They were so *normal*. The monster couldn't believe her eyes. Were these really Goblins, the raiding, murderous monsters that adventurers hunted for bronze coins? Then she heard a voice grunting by her ear.

"Ur."

The girl turned in fright. A Goblin was glaring at her. She turned to run, but he wasn't raising his sword to attack. Instead, he was pointing.

What? The monster girl looked around wildly, and then realized.

She was in the way! She was blocking the doorway! The Goblin edged by her as she scrambled aside. She looked fearfully at him, but he just snorted at her and marched out the doorway. He came back in a few moments later with a pot he'd filled with fresh snow. He glanced at her as he walked back towards the fire, but did nothing else.

They didn't care about her. They didn't fear her or—or her face. The idea struck the creature dumb with shock. She watched, awed and amazed as the Goblin with the pot hung it over the fire. The snow began to melt in the pot, and she realized they were going to make dinner.

From what? The thing looked, and saw something lying in a corner of the room. Were those rags?

No. Bodies.

Suddenly, her heart froze in her chest. The monster stared as one of the Goblins approached the corpses of Humans and one Goblin, knife in hand. That was right. Goblins ate the dead, even their own.

They were monsters just like her.

Suddenly, the horror felt a pang in her stomach, and realized she was starving. Even if she forgot for a moment, she was always consumed by it. The unrelenting, unending *emptiness* in her stomach.

She stared at the corpses, salivating quietly. She longed to eat the frozen bodies—even if they were rotten and foul. She would eat her own kind, even though her soul revolted. She would eat the Goblins too, and her own flesh if it meant filling the hole inside of her.

The monster edged towards the pile of bodies. Food. The Goblins were looking at her now and then, but they wouldn't stop her, would they? It was food. If they stopped her, she would bite them, tear at them. She had to eat. She was so *hungry*—

Her jaw opened. The thing reached for a body, and then saw something move towards her. Something big.

She turned, and saw the Hobgoblin stand up. He'd been sitting quietly amidst his fellows while they worked, helping to chop wood into smaller bits to feed the fire, but now he stood. He was clearly the leader of the group—even the former young woman knew that. She'd heard tales of Hobgoblins, feared even by Silver-rank adventurers for their strength and cunning in battle.

And now he was looking. At. Her.

The Hobgoblin grunted as he slowly walked over to the monster. She stared up at him, awed by his sheer size. He was *massive*, tall as a tall Human man, and far wider. But all that flesh wasn't fat—it was muscle, rippling, tough, *raw*—

She tore her eyes away from his body. Fearfully, the monster girl retreated a bit. What was he going to do? Was he going to—

The Hobgoblin pointed at the thing and it—she—froze, about to dart away, back into the darkness of the city. But he didn't grab for her. Rather he opened his mouth and spoke.

“In.”

It was a word! An actual word! The young woman froze, eyes wide. Goblins could *speak*? He could—speak?

Yes, he could. The Hobgoblin concentrated, frowning mightily. He forced out more syllables, his voice thick with concentration.

“Inkreepr. You. You innkreeper?”

Innkeeper? The girl had no idea what he meant. He pointed at her and repeated the word.

“Innkeeper. You? Clss.”

Her class? He was asking...?

Slowly, wide-eyed, the horror shook her head. She'd never been an [Innkeeper], never even considered it. She had been—she'd used to raise flowers. Even the thought made her heart ache. Flowers? Who needed flowers in this broken place?

The Hobgoblin stared down at her, looking surprised and even a bit irritated. He moved—she flinched again, but he just turned and growled something at another Goblin warrior sitting by the now merry fire. The Goblin stared at the girl. He was a normal-sized Goblin warrior, much like the others. He scratched his head, and muttered a word in another language.

The other Goblins stared at him, the head scratcher. One reached out and punched him on the shoulder. He grunted, but didn't punch back. Then

they all just turned and stared at the monster-girl.

For a minute they stared, and then one of them shrugged. He pointed towards the fire and beckoned towards her.

“Urg?”

Almost disbelieving, she crept forwards. She expected them to grab her at any second, to tear her clothes off and—no, even they wouldn’t sink that low, would they? But she expected them to stab at her, or to chase her away?

But nothing happened. The Goblins just stared at her, and let her inch closer to the fire. One of them sniffed at her—the other one poked a finger into his ear and wiggled it about. Then they went about their business.

They didn’t fear her, and clearly they had no idea what to make of her. The girl stared at them, and then saw three Goblins go over to the corpses.

Flesh.

She was there in an instant. She wanted to bite, to tear at the frozen bodies, but the Goblins had other ideas. When she grabbed a leg one of them grabbed her. She froze in fright, but the Goblin just pulled her away, grunting disapprovingly.

He had a knife in his hand. He used it to cut at the body, removing flesh swiftly, cutting away the most palatable parts. The thing salivated. It reached for the food, wanting to eat it there and then—

But the Goblins stopped her. They shook their heads at her and pulled her back. Not understanding, confused, the young woman stopped. She watched as the Goblins took the meat they’d cut and brought it over to the pot.

It was a big pot. The Hob had carried it no doubt, and it was boiling with water. Even as the monster watched, the Goblins added meat to the pot. And then...they began to cook with it.

She couldn’t believe her eyes. What were they doing? Cooking meat? But it was—it had been part of Humans and even other Goblins. It was still flesh. It was still—but it was different. The Goblins cooked the meat like... well, meat. They seasoned it with ground up spices and even added some flour to the soup they were making. And a carrot? Yes, one of the Goblins pulled out a wizened carrot from his belt. Another had a handful of pepper. And then they turned the horrible, terrible thing they’d taken from corpses into something else. Something almost wonderful.

Soup. The smell made the girl's mouth water. The memory made her eyes water. It was soup. She hadn't eaten soup since...

One of the Goblins, the one who seemed to be in charge of stirring and sampling the concoction, decided the food was done. He grabbed a wooden bowl and began ladling the steaming soup into bowls, passing them to the other Goblins. The girl watched, remembering and drooling, until one of the Goblins passed a bowl to *her*.

At first, she recoiled from the heat and the sudden nearness of the Goblin. She stared into crimson eyes, looked at the clawed hand holding the bowl. What? He was giving it to her?

To her? But she hadn't helped. And yet, the Goblin was offering it to her. The creature struggled with the act of kindness, but the starving thing in her greedily took the bowl. She wanted to say...to thank the Goblin, but she had no words.

And the Goblin had already taken his own bowl. Grinning with delight, he set near the fire, making some remark to the other Goblins. So the monster stared at the bowl in her hands, warming her cold body.

Generosity from a Goblin. The bowl was warm and let off steam that dissipated in the cold air around her. The monster stared. Then she ate.

Slowly, clumsily, she lifted the bowl. Her hands felt unused to the motion, as if they'd forgotten how. But some things didn't fade. Slowly, the young woman blew at the soup, licking at it tentatively until it was cool. Then she tilted the bowl up and tried to eat it as fast as she could, to satiate the thing in her stomach. She slurped the broth greedily, gulping down the chunks of meat and grinding the rest between her sharp teeth. Only when the girl had half-finished her bowl did she realize she was the only one eating this way.

The Goblin warriors were eating, yes, but they were eating...*civilly*. They didn't immediately gulp down the soup like she did. They put it into bowls and ate efficiently, some even using knives to fish the meat out and pop it into their mouths. The monster stared at them, soup dripping down her dirty chest.

They ate like people. And she—

She was ashamed. But she was also *hungry*, so she finished the first bowl they gave her, then the second, the third.

After that, the beast in her had had enough. Which was good, because she'd eaten more than the Goblins had expected. They brewed a second

batch of soup, eying her oddly but saying nothing.

They didn't say much. Rather, each Goblin seemed to know what the others were thinking. That was how the monster-girl found herself sitting at the fire as the others sat around her. They didn't say much, but that was because they were busy.

They were staring at her. Now that they'd eaten and taken care of the essentials, the Goblins studied the strange Human, the monster that had followed them to their camp. They eyed her from head to toe, unabashedly scrutinizing every part of her.

They didn't seem to know what to make of her. She didn't know what she was either, so she just stared back, part of her still afraid. The other part...

Curious.

What would they do? They hadn't hurt her so far. Instead they'd been—she hadn't seen other people—other Humans of her kind, that was, making soup in the city. But these Goblins had made fire, cleaned up the building, even offered food to a stranger.

They could speak! They had words! And she did not.

What were they? What was she? The monster felt anguish in her heart

And then a stone fell into her lap.

She nearly shrieked in surprise, but it was just a pebble. One of the Goblins had thrown it. He immediately received a kick from the others, but now they were all staring at the monster, waiting to see what she would do.

The creature stared at the stone in her lap and picked it up awkwardly. She held it in her hands and stared at the Goblin who'd thrown it. He looked vaguely ashamed. What did he want from her? She didn't know.

Slowly, hesitantly, she threw the stone back. And missed.

Her aim was terrible. Rather than hit the Goblin who'd thrown it, the pebble flew up and to the left. It struck the Hob sitting behind the Goblin, who'd been eating another bowl of soup.

The pebble bounced right off of the Hobgoblin's head. He blinked as it splashed in his bowl of soup, and slowly looked down. His chest had been splattered by the hot liquid.

The monster immediately wanted to run and hide, but she was paralyzed by shock. She stared fearfully at the Hobgoblin. So did the other Goblin warriors. They stared, and then one of them made a sound.

He hooted, and pointed at the Hobgoblin. He slapped the ground, and *laughed!* So did the other Goblins.

They laughed! In an instant, all of them were roaring with uncontrolled laughter, all, except for the Hob who was still processing his reduced bowl of soup. But the other Goblins were filled with mirth. They laughed like people, slapping their sides with mirth, hooting and pointing fingers at the Hobgoblin who picked the stone out with two fat fingers and hurled it over his shoulder.

He glared at the monster, who cringed, but with no real anger in him. Instead, the Hob reached out and flicked the head of the Goblin who'd thrown the stone at her, and then downed the remaining soup in his bowl in a single go. He sighed, chuckled ruefully, and then he laughed too.

Laughter. It was something that was Human or rather—reminded the young woman of Humans. But the Goblins and Humans laughed so much alike, even if the Goblins' voices were higher and they had an odd cadence to their tones. But they still laughed, needing no words to tell her what they meant.

They laughed, at such a small accident with all the good cheer the young woman had ever seen. And—the girl thought—almost as if they were just relieved to have an excuse to laugh.

At last, the Goblins stopped laughing, but the mood remained. They sat around the fire, exchanging short, sometimes monosyllabic bursts of chatter, but clearly speaking to each other. The thing couldn't understand, but it lay by the fire, somehow contented just to be.

It was so strange. She'd never felt this way. Not for...over a week. And few times in her previous life, to be honest. But here, among the Goblins, she needed to do nothing. She just existed, and that was enough.

Goblins. The crimson eyes of the warriors sitting around her flashed in the darkness. But they weren't heartless eyes. And their faces, however different they were from Human faces, were still capable of expressing emotion.

Soon, they began to go to sleep. They rolled into their blankets or just sat with a back against the wall and closed their eyes. Then the monster stirred.

She shouldn't be here. That was what she felt. They were sleeping, but she—

She wasn't safe here, was she? They'd given her food, but somehow, she still felt like an invader, or a monster living amongst people.

She should go. This had been—enough. This moment.

The monster crept away from the fire, heart aching. But she couldn't stay. The fire was dying down and with it, the fear was coming back. The terror.

The city was full of darkness. Darkness and death. The dead were coming back. There was violence in the streets. Other people—

She had to hide. Find a tiny crevice to hide in while she slept.

That was what she thought. But the young woman paused as she crept towards the door and saw the Goblin standing watch.

He was sitting, actually. But he was sitting high up, on a broken ledge that allowed him to look out at the streets surrounding the building they'd barricaded themselves in. The Goblin had a bow in his hands and he narrowed his eyes at the monster-girl as she scrambled up to stare at him.

He didn't smile at her, but neither did he kick her off and down onto the street. The thing looked at him, fearfully, but after a moment he just went back to studying the darkness. She looked as well and her eyes—able to see in the night like day—spotted shapes, moving in the distance.

Zombies.

She shuddered, and the Goblin on watch looked at her, almost amused. He nodded, and tapped the bow at his side. Then he pointed. The young woman turned, and saw a shape lurching down the snowy street towards them. Her heart twisted in her chest as she saw a zombie coming straight at them.

But the Goblin wasn't afraid. He raised the bow at his side and grinned at her. He pointed, tapping his chest, and then put an arrow to the string with one swift movement. He drew the arrow to his chest, and sighted down the shaft.

Fft. The arrow streaked across the void, and *thunked* into the zombie's forehead. The young woman stared, and the Goblin grinned. He pointed again. She looked, and saw another zombie, far off, not coming this way.

But it had been marked, and so the Goblin archer drew another arrow. He nocked, aimed, loosed in a single motion. The zombie staggered and fell.

Twice more the Goblin did this, pointing out targets to the monster girl and downing them. Each time he grinned at her, and tapped his own chest.

His self-satisfaction was obvious, and he was unashamed of it. He was a master at his craft, an expert showing his skills off to her, like the [Hunters] or [Marksmen] who'd do the same with targets at fairs.

After the fourth zombie had fallen, the Goblin seemed done. He went back to studying the landscape. He looked at the monster, and nodded to the dim embers of the fire inquiringly. She hesitated, and then nodded back, awkwardly.

It was warm near the embers, so the creature crept closer. She lay down there—so close she could smell the smoke and feel the heat on her skin. The dim glow burned in her vision, and she closed her eyes, feeling sleep crawl over her slowly.

Could she stay here? Was this alright? She didn't know. All the girl who'd become a monster knew was that she didn't feel the need to hide anymore. Not here.

She slept, feeling safe for the first time in a long while.

Badarrow saw the Human girl go to sleep at last by the fire. He saw her chest rise and fall rhythmically, and knew that now would be the time to shoot her, if any. He had an arrow in his hands, and he could put one through the back of her skull in a second if he wanted.

But—no. It would be a waste of an arrow. That was how Badarrow felt.

He didn't waste arrows. Ever. When Badarrow shot at the enemy, whether it was zombies, Humans, Drakes, Gnolls, or even other Goblins he never wasted an arrow. Even if he missed. Because that arrow was there to hurt the people who were trying to hurt them, and it would do just that, or at least make them cover their heads.

But killing the Human girl? No. She wasn't an enemy, and she wasn't a nuisance either. She was something else. But what?

Not a victim. Not something to attack. Garen Redfang was very clear on that one point. He had walked among Humans, and adopted some of their customs. In this at least, he was firm. No Goblin warrior of his would ever assault a female, or male for that matter. They had their own kind for such things, and it was only the worst of tribes that tolerated such actions among their own people. So why degrade themselves for other species?

It was a mark of pride among the Redfang Goblins that they were like their leader. Humans were for killing or ignoring. That was it. Nothing else.

So. No sex. No killing. Just a Human who ate their food and slept next to them as if they were Humans like her. Badarrow couldn't understand it. But she was clearly more monster than Human, so maybe that was why.

The Goblin [Archer] yawned irritably. He glanced up at the moon, and decided it was time. Swiftly, he leapt down from his spot and walked over to another of the resting Goblins.

Headscratcher woke up after only a single poke. He knew it was his time to watch, so he didn't scowl that hard at Badarrow. He took the bow the Goblin handed him, nodding at the implicit threat of what would happen if he damaged Badarrow's weapon.

The Goblin warrior went to climb up to the watch point, but he paused as he passed the Human. He stopped, and looked down at her. He stared down at the Human girl, eying her altered features with interest. He reached down to touch at her dirty hair, which glowed in the firelight—

Badarrow kicked him. Headscratcher nearly tumbled into the firepit. He turned, fist raised, but Badarrow's glare stopped him. One jerk of the annoyed Goblin's head clearly said that Headscratcher should be *keeping watch* or they'd all be dead.

Reluctantly, Headscratcher went up to his post. He kept look out, killing any zombies that came near with precise shots from the bow. Then after about an hour had passed, he went to wake the next Goblin whose turn it was. The warriors had a system for every night, so that each Goblin took their own turn unless wounded.

Tonight was Badarrow, then Headscratcher. After that Rocksoup and then Rabbiteater, and then Bitefly, and then Grunter for the last watch. Like that, they passed the night away into morning.

Just before dawn, all the Goblins woke as one. They sat up and grabbed their gear. They armed themselves within minutes, and then prepared for battle.

The thirteen Goblin warriors sat around the sleeping monster-girl in silence, polishing their weapons, checking their armor for faults. They made as little sound as possible, and stood up and left her sleeping quietly next to the fire.

The Redfang warriors chose a good vantage point where they wouldn't be seen, and watched the edge of the city, the gates where the other Goblin

army had camped. They stood alert, but not tense, conserving their energy. Waiting. They knew it would not be long.

They came into the city in groups of twenty or more, sweeping through with the dawning sun at their backs, killing anything and everything they found. Goblin warriors in black armor, preparing the way.

A group of them came across a horde of zombies. They didn't retreat; the zombies would pursue them and the last thing the warriors wanted was to run into another group of undead and become trapped.

So the Goblins found a snowy patch of land on higher ground, and let the zombies come to them. Many of the slow undead fell to arrows before they even reached the Goblins, and the others fell to the Goblins as they fought in tight formation. The Goblin warriors grinned as they slaughtered the undead. After all, they were just—

Zombies.

Eight zombies sat up in the snow behind the Goblins. They'd been lying still, motionless under the snow. Now they leapt to their feet and *ran* at the Goblins, taking the warriors by complete surprise. The Goblins cried out—turned to fight—

And a skeleton slipped out from the crowd of zombies and beheaded one of the Goblins. He turned and cut another one down even as the Goblins began fighting the eight zombies under his control. Another Goblin turned, axe raised, shouting as Toren charged him—

The skeleton's eyes glowed purple. The Goblin froze up, and then raised his axe again. But too slow, too late. Toren's hand blurred, and the Goblin stumbled back, throat cut. Toren grinned as he leapt backwards, avoiding the other Goblin warriors' attacks. The [Fear] enchantment didn't work on Goblins—but it could make them hesitate.

Their formation broken, attacked from behind and harassed by the skeleton, the group of over twenty Goblins fell quickly to the zombie horde that encircled them, no longer held at bay. Toren happily walked among their bodies, checking for a better sword and a shield. He stayed clear of the rogue zombies, the mass of dead about sixty strong now, as it shambled its way down the street. The eight zombies Toren had control of waited patiently for him to finish as he triumphantly surveyed the dead Goblins.

It hadn't been easy to get all the zombies in the right spots, but they'd been an excellent distraction. Toren couldn't command a horde, but it was easy to herd them like cattle and let his personal band of undead capitalize on their attack. And the dividends of Toren's hard work were immediately obvious.

[Leader Level 4!]

[Skill – Daring Charge obtained!]

The skeleton danced about with his new sword and shield. Another level! He'd been sending his zombies to attack Humans all night, but it was clear that attacking groups that could fight back was more rewarding. He immediately led his zombies off, searching for more Goblin groups. It looked like they were finally coming to attack, and that made Toren happy.

He'd finally get to kill a lot of things today.

Another group of Goblins, twenty five warriors of the Goblin Lord, cornered the group of thirteen Redfang warriors an hour after dawn. Both sides were breathing heavily.

It had been a long chase. The Redfang warriors had caught the first group of Goblins by surprise, slaying over half with arrows before they'd known what was happening. But by chance, another group of warriors had heard the fighting and rushed to assist their comrades. The Redfang warriors had fled, bringing down more Goblins, but now their backs were against a wall.

“Traitors.”

The Goblin warrior with black armor and a longsword in his hand called out to the Redfang warriors. He stood with the black-armored warriors at his back.

“Goblin Lord is. Obey him. Come and not die.”

For a second, the thirteen Goblins paused in surprise. This was new. They were being invited to join the Goblin Lord's forces? They looked at each other, uncertain, thinking.

Then Rocksoup fished around in his nose for a booger, and flicked it at the other Goblin leader. The Goblin roared in outrage, but Rocksoup's

comrades, his friends, slapped him on the back and cheered.

The Redfang Goblins laughed. They faced down the other Goblins, backs straight, heads held high. They did not need to say anything. Any true Goblin would understand.

We are here. We are Goblins. We do not abandon our tribe.

No true Goblin would. What were these false Goblins, these fools who'd accept traitors into their tribe? Who could obey a Chieftain—even Goblin Lord like that?

Never. It could never be accepted. So the Goblins faced off, the Redfang warriors standing proud as the sun hit their backs.

It was thirteen against twenty-five. The black-armored Goblins were confident, but the Redfang warriors had no fear. Grunter waited until the thunder in his heart was right, and then roared.

As one, the Redfang warriors leapt forwards. They rushed ahead, shouting without fear as they ran towards their surprised enemy. For all his bulk, Grunter was first. He lowered his axe and shoulder-charged into a group of warriors, ignoring their weapons. He trusted his thick skin and armor to keep him safe.

A Goblin stabbed at him, but the shaft of his spear broke as Grunter rammed into him. The Hob trampled the Goblin, and seized another. He threw him, and then the one he'd stepped on as if they weighed nothing.

Grunter threw two Goblins into their fellows, turned, and chopped another Goblin down. He roared at the others, making them draw back in fear. They dared to challenge *him*? He was a Hob! He scythed left and right with his heavy weapon, daring anyone to come close.

Headscratcher was right behind Grunter. He leapt towards the warriors Grunter had downed and without a second's thought, stabbed them as they struggled to get up. Behind him, Badarrow shot the other Goblin leader through the head at point-blank range, laughing in fury as he did.

The other Redfang warriors formed a spear, Grunter at their head. They charged at the other warriors, bringing the fight to them. Bugear jabbed with a spear, keeping three Goblins at bay at once. One ran forwards, slashing, but Rocksoup was there!

Rocksoup and the Goblin cut—but it was the other Goblin warrior who fell away. Too slow! The dagger in Rocksoup's off-hand caught the Goblin in his unprotected throat and he fell, choking.

The Goblin Lord's warriors fell back in disarray. They hadn't expected such a difference in levels! But the Redfang warriors refused to give them any moment's rest. They pressed on, howling with fury.

They were elites! They'd fought beside Garen Redfang in the hottest of battles! Other Goblin warriors couldn't compare to their skill.

But—they were outnumbered. And not even their levels and skill in battle could bridge the gap in numbers so easily. The instant the other Goblin warriors lost the shock of first contact, they began to swarm the Redfang warriors, fighting two-to-one, or in Grunter's case, *six-to-one*.

Still, the Redfang warriors refused to back down. They fought shoulder-to-shoulder, refusing to budge. If this was their last moment, they'd go down as free Goblins, not these pale imitations. Headscratcher had lost his blade—buried in a Goblin's spine and was falling back when he saw something *blur* at the backs of the Goblin warriors besieging them. He heard screams, and then the press forcing the Redfang warriors disappeared.

A silver blade cut four Goblins to the ground in swift slashes that rent their armor. The Redfang warriors saw a Goblin in black armor turn—and then a shield crashed into his face. He fell, neck broken, and then they saw the man in silver armor.

"What's this?"

Ylawes raised his shield as the black armor Goblins fled around him. The Redfang warriors were clearly different from the rest, and he narrowed his eyes at Grunter. The Redfang Goblins didn't hesitate. The moment they saw who they were facing, they moved to attack.

The warriors spread out around Ylawes, half of them pulling out bows. Grunter, Rocksoup, Bugear and three more Goblins formed a circle around the adventurer, keeping a wide distance. They closed as one.

Ylawes didn't let the Goblins take the initiative. The instant they moved to attack him, he charged left. Bugear raised his own shield and the sword that Ylawes brought down cracked it and flattened the Goblin. If it wasn't for his own Skill, the Goblin would have been cut apart in a single blow.

The warrior in silver armor clearly hadn't expected the Goblin to survive, but he turned and blocked Grunter's powerful blow as the Hob charged him. The axe with all of Grunter's weight behind it bounced off the shield, and the man instantly riposted, his blade cutting Grunter deep in the side.

The Hob howled and the other Goblins swarmed Ylawes. The man spun away, keeping all of them at bay. Arrows flew at his face—he blocked each one with his shield, spinning to knock them down.

The Redfang warriors paused then, in consternation and for the first time, fear. For his part, Ylawes eyed them with his own degree of shock.

“Hmf. You’re no ordinary Goblins, are you? Are all the monsters this far south so strange?”

The Redfang warriors made no reply. Instead, they just pulled back. Grunter kept one hand on his side, assessing his damage. They looked at each other, seeing the terrible truth in each others’ eyes.

This adventurer was Gold-rank. He had to be.

It was a death sentence for the Redfang warriors. They knew it. A group of Silver-rank adventurers they could handle, or run from. But a Gold-rank?

Badarrow snarled as he loosed arrow after arrow at Ylawes. The man blocked each shot, advancing quickly on the Goblins. The Redfang warriors spread out again, but this time they had only one goal in mind. Even if they died, even if they all died distracting the adventurer, they had to give Grunter an opening—

Headscratcher, Bugear, and Bitefly all attacked at once. They slashed at Ylawes, ducking back as he slashed at them, trying to distract him. Other Goblins attacked at the same time, and Ylawes was forced to knock aside their blades, force them back with his sword rather than attack. Grunter spotted an opening as the man turned to cut Headscratcher down. The small Goblin raised his sword bravely, and Grunter exploded towards Ylawes with a *roar*—

The man turned and lashed out with his shield, smashing into Grunter’s right arm. All of the Goblins heard the Hob’s bones *break* from the impact. Grunter staggered, but he still tried to bring his axe down—

“Courage. Even from Goblins.”

That was all Ylawes said as he ran Grunter through. The Hob’s eyes widened and he sat down as Ylawes pulled the blade out of his stomach. The Redfang warriors howled and attacked, but too slow. Ylawes raised his crimson blade for the final blow—

No!

Was it a word or a thought? She didn’t know. But the monster leapt, and her flight across the ten feet of ground caught Ylawes by surprise. Even so, the adventurer still turned fast enough. His shield smacked the young

woman out of the air. She landed, stunned, and saw his sword point down at her.

But Ylawes didn't finish the blow. He stopped at the last moment, and his eyes went wide as he saw her face. He seemed horrified; his face went pale.

"You. What are—?"

Grunter *threw* himself at the Gold-rank adventurer. Ylawes turned, and his shield came up, smashing into the Hob's face and stopping his charge. But the impact still made the adventurer slide a bit in the snow.

The Hob stumbled, bleeding. Ylawes shoved him back, and then turned towards the thing crouching in the snow again. She slashed at him, forcing him to guard his body with his shield. Her claws could scratch even his plate armor.

"What's wrong with you? Please, if you can—answer me!"

She only screamed, screamed at him without words to stop, to not kill these people. But he was too strong. He forced her away, hitting her in the stomach with his shield so hard she was stunned. And then he turned back to the Goblins.

They faced him, ready to die. But Ylawes' eyes narrowed, and his head turned. Almost too late.

The blurring [Mirage Cut] opened up a deep slash across the silver armored man's cheek. He turned, snarling, and Toren rolled away, clattering his teeth with frustration.

"You!"

Ylawes charged at the skeleton, but halted as an arrow flew at his face. He turned towards Badarrow as the Goblin reached for another arrow in his quiver.

That's when the zombies charged out the alleyway. Eight of them ran at Ylawes, arms swinging wildly. He hacked through four in an instant, his limbs a blur of motion, but Toren was at his back. The skeleton cut at Ylawes as the Redfang warriors made him retreat, trying to strike the man's face, cut at the joints in his armor—

"*Stop!*"

The Gold-rank adventurer bellowed at the Human, or at least the thing that had once been Human. He saw her turn to look back at him once, but then she was helping pull the Hob away.

He didn't have time to chase her. Somehow, an entire horde of zombies had been attracted to his location, and they surrounded him now. Ylawes cut them asunder, his blade and shield moving ceaselessly, but there was always the skeleton, trying to cut at him, forcing the adventurer to fight with his back to the wall—

In the end, Toren leapt away as the last few zombies kept Ylawes in place. The Gold-rank adventurer cut the last corpse to the ground and one booted foot smashed a skull in. The man and skeleton stared at each other across the street full of corpses.

“What *are* you?”

Toren just grinned. Then he ran and disappeared down a street, leaving Ylawes behind in the snow. The adventurer turned to stare at the bodies of the fallen.

“First Goblins fighting Goblins. Then—a young woman? A monster? Something. And then that skeleton. What's going on?”

No one answered him. But soon the adventurer turned and raced through the streets. He could hear screams everywhere, even at the walls he'd had guards posted at. The Goblins were trying to kill everyone they could before the main fist of their army attacked. He had to save them all.

But he could not do it alone. The adventurer halted and reached for his belt. He took out a scroll and stared at shimmering letters. Words. A reply. Soon.

He tucked the scroll back into his belt pouch and ran on, sword and shield raised. To save the living. Or die defending them.

The Goblin commander *roared* his fury as the [Scouts] brought back news. The kill teams he'd sent into the city were being routed! Slaughtered! By a Human with silver armor and the *undead*!

He rounded on the two cringing [Shamans] who'd been forced to carry their master's burden. He pointed at the city, demanding they control the undead, to send them in. But the [Shamans] could not. They had not the strength, not a fraction of the head [Shaman] that had been sent to lead the army, and certainly not nearly as much as the Goblin Lord himself—

The commander of the Goblins had no time for excuses. He called out, and his mount, a vast Shield Spider, rose up. It *bit* one of the [Shamans],

cutting off his shriek. The other one fled as the commander called his lieutenants. He pointed to the city, and gave crisp orders.

No more waiting! No more delays for reinforcements. The [Shamans] could collect their dead after he'd slaughtered everyone in the city. The adventurer and all the Humans would die.

The Goblin army prepared to march on Esthelm. And in its streets, a skeleton danced, bringing death and commanding it. And further away, a group of Goblins carrying a bleeding Hob. A monster ran with them, helping them carry the dying Goblin, watching as they slapped his face, trying to keep him awake.

People.

And as the sun rose, it rose on the undead, the army of Goblins, the desperate walls built by Humans. And a few people, caught in the madness.

This is their story.

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3.20 T

This is the story of a monster. She knew she was a monster. She'd eaten people. Her own kind, rotting, crawling with insects and maggots and decay.

She'd done it to survive. But the cost had been almost too much to bear. More than once, the young woman who'd once had a name wished she had died back then rather than take that first bite.

But she was alive. And she still longed to live, even now. But the monster in her—

It *hungered*. It always wanted out. There was a part of her soul that would devour the world if it could. It would eat and eat until there was nothing left to eat but itself.

That was what she feared. Walking any deeper down this road to hell would mean never coming back. Of that she was sure.

She was a monster. A horrible thing, a creature to be hunted and killed by heroes and adventurers. But that was the thing. The girl that looked like a monster had encountered real monsters. Goblins. And somehow, they were more like people than the Humans living in Esthelm.

Goblins. The most pathetic species, the cowardly, backstabbing creatures that ate their own dead. That was what the [Florist] had been told when she'd walked on two legs and known her name. But the thing that scuttled around on all fours with jagged claws and sharp teeth saw something different.

She saw people. People—warriors, proud and courageous. The Goblins who'd saved her once ran through the streets, armed, keeping the way clear while six of their number helped support and drag the massive Hobgoblin they carried between them.

His eyes were fluttering, and the massive Goblin was fading. Blood trailed from his stomach, spattering on the snow and dirty ground. He was cut deeply.

A Gold-rank adventurer had done that to him. The monster had seen it. He'd been killing monsters and he'd fought the Goblins. And she'd fought him, to let them get away.

Even now she didn't know why she'd done it. She'd attacked her own people—a hero! But he'd been wrong. The Goblins were not monsters. They were heroes too.

They'd fought. With their backs against the wall, even against an *adventurer*—they'd fought. That was all the monster thought as she helped drag the half-conscious Hob back towards their camp.

They were monsters, yes. But even they—no, they weren't nearly as pathetic as she was. And she had saved them. Or tried. She'd fought against a hero, an adventurer—

For them.

What had possessed her? Perhaps only a desire not to let these people die. To repay them for the kindness they'd shown her. Because they weren't monsters.

Only she was a monster.

The Goblin warriors were shouting in panic as they ran through the streets. They were shouting at the Hob, trying to keep him awake. The massive Goblin was stumbling, barely lucid, but none of the Goblins dared slow down. They kept watching their backs, waiting at any moment for the man in silver armor to pursue them.

But he never came. And when the Goblins had gotten to their camp and the Hob collapsed on the ground, they immediately tore at his belt.

The monster squatted in a corner, fingers in her mouth, watching, not knowing what to do. One of the Goblins was undoing all the compartments in the belt, searching for something. What?

A healing potion! Of course! The red vial was tiny, but from the way it glittered in the light, the monster knew it was very powerful. She caught her breath as they poured the liquid into the Hob's gaping stomach wound. And in an instant—

It closed! The thing had never seen any wound heal that fast, but the potion was the kind only the rich would use. The Hob groaned, but color flooded back into his green face. He sat up—

And clutched at his arm. The potion hadn't mended his broken bones. The other Goblin warriors sighed in relief. One reached for the Hob's arm, but he shoved the Goblin away. Wincing, the Hob felt at his injuries and then pointed. A Goblin fished around in their packs and came up with cloth and a metal bar they'd used to hold the cooking pot with.

The Hob began to create a splint with the materials. Other Goblins wanted to help, but he clearly wanted to do it by himself. He snapped at the other Goblins when they tried to approach.

The monster watched this, even more sure that she had been right and the adventurer wrong. These were not monsters to be killed, at least, these Goblins weren't.

They cared for each other. Impulsively, the young woman reached out. She touched Grunter's arm as he grunted in pain and annoyance, fumbling with the splint.

The Hob moved to push the creature away, but paused when he saw her. He hesitated, and then reluctantly let her take the splint. Slowly, slowly, trying to remember how the motions worked, the young woman tied the splint to his arm. The Hob gasped, but made a sound when she stopped.

Tighter. That was clearly what he said, what he meant. The monster-girl tied the knot, as the Hob gasped, but when it was done he stood and grunted at her.

Thanks. That was all it was, but it made the monster's eyes fill with tears. The Hob paused and gently bent to wipe them away.

And then the monster was no monster, but a young woman who looked like one. The Redfang warriors crowded around her, slapping her back, gargling in approval at her. Looking at her—

As a person. It was all the young woman wanted. So she wept and for a second, forgot the hunger in her soul.

This is the tale of a monster. This is the tale of a young woman with something dark in her soul. She felt it, even as she sat in the Goblin's camp, listening to them laugh and slap each other with the sheer, giddy relief of being alive.

She was still a monster. She still wanted to *eat*, to tear the flesh off of her newfound friends and—

But she couldn't. She wouldn't. And yet the thing knew it couldn't stay. Eventually, she would become—

A Goblin pressed a bowl of reheated soup into her hands. He grinned at her as he scratched at his head. She stared at him. He looked familiar. He

was the first Goblin who'd come for her. Her eyes went to his head, and she recoiled.

He had *ticks*! The Goblin looked vaguely apologetic as he scratched at one dark shape buried on his bald head. The girl grabbed at him, and much to his surprise, dragged him over to the fire the other Goblins were restarting. There she picked up a stick and to the other Goblins' astonishment, lit one end until it was hot.

The head-scratching Goblin had no idea what she intended, and thus when he saw the hot stick heading for his head he immediately tried to pull away. But the monster-girl made soothing noises and he stopped. He was very tense in her arms as she poked at the ticks with her stick.

The flaming end made the Goblin yelp and try to pull away, but it didn't seem to make the tick want to leave. Frowning, the young woman cast aside the stick and grabbed at the Goblin's head.

Nails, then. She picked at the skin, her elongated nails digging into the flesh. The Goblin *screeched* and tried to get away then—but he paused when she pulled the first tick off of his head.

Headscratcher and the other Goblins stared in horror at the huge tick, big and fat from living off his scalp as the Human girl pulled it out of his head. Immediately, the other Goblins crowded around Headscratcher's head and recoiled as they saw how infested it was.

Beseechingly, Headscratcher put his head on the Human's lap. She seemed stunned, but then obligingly dug her fingers into Headscratcher's skin, gently, pulling bugs out. She flicked them into the fire. Once or twice, Headscratcher thought she was looking at them as if she was hungry but she never ate them.

Once it was over, the Goblin's head was bleeding, but mercifully, no longer itching. He grinned at the Human and only got a strange look in reply. He thought she would have been happy, but when she looked at his face—

It almost looked like she was about to cry.

The young woman sat in the snow next to the fire. She rubbed at the dirty ball in her hands. Soap. Lye soap, strongly scented, pilfered no doubt from some caravan the Goblins had raided.

But soap nonetheless. And they had cloth and oil. More things that made them civilized, made them people. Slowly, the girl abandoned the soap and dunked her hands into hot water. It made her hands *burn*, but it was necessary. She was filthy.

Yes, wasn't that how it went? Clean hands and—and doing things. Small things. Not eating the dead. If she could do things like this, then—

The young woman stared at the Goblin curled up into a ball next to her. He was practically frozen with fright, and the other four Goblins holding him looked grim and determined. He hadn't wanted her help, but they'd insisted.

Several tiny mites crawled out of the shivering Goblins' ear even as the young woman watched. They made her...hungry, but she put away the thought. Infestation. Bugs. She'd seen it before, seen a [Healer] treat it. She could try the same, couldn't she?

The Goblin whose ticks she'd pulled out—the head scratching Goblin—handed her a stick with a bit of cloth wrapped around the end. It was very thin, and the girl dipped lightly in a pot of oil sitting next to her. Her Goblin patient shuddered when he saw the stick, but the other Goblins held him down.

Gently, very gently, the young woman swabbed the Goblin's ear with the cloth and oil. He gritted his teeth and growled inaudible words into her lap, but didn't move. Bugs came out with the stick, stuck on the oil. The other Goblins made a face when the girl kept pulling out bugs. One of them slapped the Goblin on the ear as if it was his fault he'd let them in there.

Too many bugs. No matter how hard the girl tried, she kept getting more with each stick and she was sure there were probably eggs in there. So she changed tactics.

Hot water, poured in the Goblin's pointed ear. He yelped and struggled, but his friends just laughed and held him down. The girl counted to ten and then let him sit up and drain his ear.

Tiny little bugs washed out with the water. The girl made a face and did it again, this time with soapy water. She made the Goblin keep the water in his ear for several minutes; long enough to drown whatever was in there.

When she let him sit up, the Goblin glared at her and stuck a finger in his ear. But when he only pulled out dead bugs, he brightened up. He grinned at her and waved a hand. She smiled back.

And cried.

It was something the other Goblins couldn't understand. But the young woman felt—*normal* after helping the Goblin. His gratitude hurt her in ways no sword could ever do.

Of course, she couldn't explain that. The other Goblins crowded around the former bug-eared Goblin. One smacked him on the back of the head. Another punched him. The young woman stopped them. Tried to explain.

There was a patch of dirt on the ground next to the fire. The young woman took a stick and drew in it. She drew a stick figure, and then small ones for the Goblins. They crowded around to look, and the one who scratched his head sat across from her, staring at the young woman's face.

Her. Goblins. They nodded and pointed at each other, drawing an exaggeratedly fat Goblin for the Hob who lay resting against one wall. The girl nodded, face bleak, and they quieted. She pointed to the figure representing her in the dark.

Me.

She added fangs and horns to the little figure in the dirt.

Monster.

They stared at her. Their eyes found the way her teeth had changed, her jaw, her fingers and even arms, making her less...Human. More like an Eater, whatever that was. But then they shrugged at her.

So what? A Goblin patted the young woman's hand and grinned at her. He pointed to himself and the others and drew little horns on all of the figures. They were all monsters.

The young woman's eyes filled, but she didn't weep. She pointed at the figure, and then drew other figures, other Humans. Far away from her. She drew a line between herself and the others.

Alone.

The other Goblins stopped smiling. They stared at her, and at the line separating her. They understood. None of them said a word. They just understood.

The young woman pointed to a body. She pointed to the dead flesh, mimed eating. The Goblins nodded. She drew a line down her face.

Sad.

A tear travelled down the grime, washing it away. The Goblins stared at her, and then at the bodies.

They understood.

And she understood. Somehow, in the ways they tried to tell her, in the motions of their arms. They felt it too.

Because of course Goblins ate their dead. Of course they did. To survive, they would eat anything. Everyone knew that. Eating their own kind and other people was what made Goblins monsters.

But who would have asked Goblins how they felt? Did anyone realize the Goblins wept to eat their own dead? Of course Goblins ate their own kind. They did it to survive. But every single Goblin drew a line down their cheeks.

They did, and they wept inside.

They were people too. People who wanted to live.

They were monsters with souls. And they—

They were no different from her. No worse than she'd been, and perhaps better. They weren't monsters.

And perhaps she wasn't either.

This is the story of a monster girl. She sat in the ruins of her home and wept. For everything she'd lost. For everything she'd become. She wept because she had done horrible things to survive, horrible things that had made her despair and want to die. But she had met monsters, and it turned out they were more Human than she was. And then they'd shown her their hearts and it had turned out she was no monster either.

The young woman wept, sobbing for all she'd lost. She was lost, alone. But then she felt the arms around her, and looked up into the face of Headscratcher. He squeezed her tight, eyes closed.

This is the story of a Goblin who hugged a monster. And the monster yearned to bite him, to eat—

But she forced the desires down in her chest. She buried the madness and found something else sprouting in the darkness of her heart. It bloomed, a faint sprout reaching towards the light, drinking in the moment of kindness.

A flower.

[Condition – Terrible Hunger Removed!]

The voice made her eyes go wide. The girl stood up, knocking the Goblin's hands away. He let go instantly, afraid he'd gone too far. But the young woman stared up at the sky and saw only blue. A bit of blue hiding behind the dark clouds.

Sunlight. Far off, but still there, shining down. Redemption for a shattered soul. Thanks, for a Goblin.

He was saying something. Trying to apologize. The young woman looked at him, and embraced him to his great surprise. The other Goblins gaped, but she hugged him, lifting him up into the air.

She still looked like a monster. Her teeth were still sharp, and she had lost the words. But she was no longer hungry. That was enough.

She hugged him, and wept. A monster, hugging a Goblin. But a monster with a soul. And a bit more Human in them than had been there a minute ago. So it whispered to the young woman, as she tried to remember her name, knowing she had one.

Salvation.

The man wearing silver armor stood at the head of the battlements and stared down at the people. They looked up to him for hope, for redemption. For a chance to live again.

"The Goblins are coming."

That was all he said to them, Esthelm's remaining thousands. They held weapons in their hands, children, women, men, clinging to life with all they had. He had never been prouder, never been more honored to fight.

"They are coming! Their first assault failed. They'll be coming in force, next. All of them."

The dead lay in the streets, and what few he had saved had now joined the living. The Goblins had swept through the city, killing teams of them. But they were dead now, avenged. He had slain nearly a hundred himself, and the others—

Ylawes looked out past the barricade he stood on, out into the city. Zombies wandered the streets, by the hundreds. Thousands. And somewhere, hiding, striking whenever his back was turned, was the skeleton. It had killed Goblins and Humans alike. But it was one skeleton compared to the army about to march.

The Gold-rank adventurer turned to the people again. He pointed to the barricades—built with stone and wood and anything that could be scavenged, manned by anyone with a bow or weapon that could hold off the hordes.

“We have the high ground, and we’ve created chokepoints that we can hold.”

One main entry point with palisades. A killing field, or so he hoped. He would hold it until he died. And these people—Ylawes pointed at them, shouting.

“They will come. They will come and we will fight and die here. Do you understand? *Here*. To the last child. There is nowhere to run, nowhere to hide! Your city lives or dies on this day! People of Esthelm, reclaim your pride. Throw back the Goblins and retake your city!”

He raised his sword and they roared. They would have cheered anyone, but they cheered him. They called out for hope and raised their weapons against the darkness.

“Do you really think we can live, sir?”

“I told you to call me Ylawes.”

The man turned and looked the Bronze-rank adventurer in the eye. He was glad the young man had stayed, he and his two friends. And because he respected the man’s courage, he didn’t lie.

“The odds are slim. But it’s possible. We have the Goblins’ numbers. We may even outnumber them by a bit.”

“Counting women and children sir. And people who can barely fight—”

“That’s what the barricades and I will have to equalize. Other than that, we can only hope that the people of Esthelm fight with all the courage they have today. If we can kill a good number of them, our enemy may disperse. They might have armor and some training, but they’re still low-level Goblins. At least, most of them are. In truth, it’s the undead that concern me most.”

“So many...”

“Yes. I was too late.”

Ylawes said it simply. He stared down at the streets.

“The Goblins will control them with [Shamans] and [Mages] if they can. Use them to fight. If we have to battle both undead and Goblins, we stand no chance.”

“If that happens—then what will we do?”

“Hold out. For as long as possible. Aid may arrive soon.”

“Are you sure?”

The man looked at him, wanting to believe. So did Ylawes. He reached for a belt pouch and pulled something out.

“I sent for help last night.”

He showed the adventurer a scroll with glowing letters etched onto the parchment. A message. And—underneath it, a reply had been written in terse, neat script.

“Help is coming. But I don’t know if it will come here in an hour or in days.”

“We don’t have days.”

They didn’t even have an hour. And both adventurers knew that. Ylawes looked to the horizon, and raised his voice.

“To arms! The Goblins are coming!”

The dark mass at the edge of the city limits was moving. On the walls, the Humans saw a dark tide of bodies surging into the city, and then heard rhythmic impacts.

Drumbeats. Not just one or two, but countless numbers of them, thudding impacts that made the defenders shake in fear.

The drumbeats were like thunder. And as Ylawes watched, the first wave of the Goblin army began pouring into the city. Some rode Shield Spiders—others horses. And at the head of the army—

“Undead. The [Shamans] are controlling them.”

He gritted his teeth. Was this the end? But it was only a few undead—barely a hundred. If that was all they could control, then—

There was a chance. Ylawes shouted as he ran down the barricade, to the one opening in their defenses. He would cut them down again and again. Create a point for them to throw all their fury into until there was nothing left.

“Man the barricades. We hold them at the choke points—force them back!”

The people of Esthelm shouted, and the Goblin drums pounded. Now the Goblins screamed, and their voices ran throughout the city. They met the adventurer wearing silver and the clash was like thunder. Goblins poured up the barricades, fighting the people on the walls. Archers from both sides filled the skies—

And the undead moved. They focused on the conflict like lightning. Zombies, ghouls, advancing like the tide. Goblins turned and fought the dead—[Shamans] struggled to control them, trying, failing in the face of so many. And the man in silver fought on, sword and shield flashing in the light.

The last battle for Esthelm had begun.

He saw the man wearing silver armor. He saw the Goblins, seemingly numberless as they poured towards the wooden barricades, screaming warcries. And Toren felt happy.

War. Death. The Humans met the Goblins with a roar, clashing swords. In moments the first bodies began to fall.

And oh, how Toren longed to be among the fighting, sword in hand! But he had to be patient. He looked around, at the dead who surrounded him.

They were his kind. Thoughtless, yes, but Toren felt a connection to them he hadn't a few days ago. He and they weren't so different after all. They lived to fight and kill—

And so did he. This was his purpose. Toren knew it. He could lead the dead. Why else would he have this Skill, this class, if not because he was meant to do it? There was a special joy to ordering the zombies about, to leading them to victory through superior tactics and planning.

It was addictive, giddy, intoxicating. Toren looked at the battlefield and saw how he could shape it. He called out to the zombies under his control, readying them to move into the fray.

This was what he was meant to do. At last, he'd found it. It was so wonderful to command. Had Erin felt like this when she ordered him? Had she—

Toren paused. The burning lights in his eyes dimmed for a second. No. Not her. He was separate now. She was...not his owner any longer. He was free. Would be free.

And he would level up. Toren looked back at the battlefield. The Goblins were trying to swarm up the barricades blocking the streets off as Humans threw them off the barricades and shot arrows and threw stones down at them. Now was the time.

The first group of zombies lurched towards the Goblins. They moved slowly—just another random assortment of the undead drawn to the conflict. The Goblins barely paid any attention to them. So long as they had a few warriors guard their flanks, there was no danger.

Toren grinned. At his silent command, the zombies began to run.

This is the story of a skeleton. He only knew how to kill, so he did just that. In a city filled with death, the skeleton killed with his hands at first, and then used others to kill more and more. He would kill everything if he could.

Because it was all he knew.

“Hold the lines! *Hold, damn you!*”

Ylawes screamed at the people struggling around him as he cut with his sword, bringing down Goblins as they came at him. How long had he been fighting? A few seconds? An hour? He couldn’t tell.

Goblins poured towards him, around the palisades, into the center of a whirlwind of steel he created. Parry, strike, block, *strike*—his shield was a weapon just as much as his sword. Normal Goblins couldn’t even get close as he cut through their weapons, but there were more who attacked even as their companions fell. And when a Hob came—

Ylawes stumbled back as a javelin crashed into his chest, breaking on his armor but denting it. His plate mail was not enchanted like his arms, and he coughed. A Goblin screamed as it swung a shortsword—

He beheaded it. Keep fighting. Don’t stop! The Goblins seemed endless, but the barricades were all still holding. Even as people fell and died, more rushed to take their place. They had the high ground. So long as they had that, even a child could knock a Goblin down with a well-placed blow—

“*Zombies!*”

Someone screamed the word. Ylawes turned, and saw fourteen zombies, *sprinting* at him. He reacted instantly.

“*[Shield of Valor]!*”

The zombies *crashed* into a wall of air as Ylawes brought his shield up and *pushed*. The zombies and every Goblin in a cone in front of him were sent flying backwards by his Skill. Panting, Ylawes lowered his shield and turned.

“Report!”

An [Archer], one of the few warriors among the citizens—called out to him as she snatched at more arrows. The Goblins were pulling back, but her hands never stopped working, firing into their shielded ranks.

“Zombies are coming from every direction! They’re attacking the barricades, but some are attacking the Goblins!”

“Show me!”

Ylawes leapt up onto a platform. The woman pointed and he saw she was right. Zombies were approaching from all sides, drawn by so many living bodies. And they were attacking Goblins! Some of the undead were even fighting those controlled by the [Shamans]. But something was very, very wrong.

“What’s happening?”

The [Archer] pointed as a group of zombies began running, just as the ones earlier had. They charged into a group of Goblins from behind, biting and tearing.

“Zombies can’t run!”

“Some can.”

Ylawes was grim as he surveyed the zombies. They’d caught an entire group of archers by surprise—was it chance or had something known that there was an opportunity to strike?

“They *can*?”

The woman stared at Ylawes in horror. He nodded.

“Some can. But not like this. Only a few out of a hundred should and they don’t—group like that. This isn’t right.”

“Look! Another group!”

This time, Ylawes clearly saw what was happening. A group of zombies moving slowly towards the Goblins suddenly stiffened. In an instant, they’d changed from their slow pace into a sprint, and they changed course. Instead of hitting the group of Goblin warriors they’d been aiming towards, they ran towards a barricade and began pounding at a gap that had been exposed in the wooden structure.

“Why are they acting like that?”

“*There.*”

Ylawes pointed. At the center of a huge mass of zombies, a skeleton was standing, pointing and waving a sword about. The woman standing next to him paled.

“Dead gods. Is it *leading* them?”

“Yes.”

Ylawes saw it clearly. Wherever the skeleton pointed, a group of zombies would begin to run. They attacked vulnerable spots, hitting both Humans and Goblins alike. Always fourteen zombies. Each time the group of fourteen zombies had crashed into the Goblin flanks, another group would begin to move with that same focused intelligence.

“It’s coordinating the undead. It’s trying to overwhelm us! Watch the sides!”

Ylawes called out. He wanted to run up to see how the entire battlefield was going, but the brief window he’d created with his Skill was already up. He saw people struggling against the Goblin warriors again, and leapt back into the fray.

“Don’t falter!”

A Goblin riding a massive Shield Spider was coming straight at Ylawes, laughing as he hacked apart Humans with a halberd that cut through armor like it wasn’t there. The [Knight] roared a challenge, and the two met in a clash at the center of the battlefield. But the undead kept coming, and the barricades began to splinter under the ceaseless attacks...

They sat on the rooftop of their hideout, watching the battle. Goblins. But not *those* Goblins. The Redfang warriors felt no attachment to the warriors of the Goblin Lord. In fact, they sneered at the other side’s tactics.

Sieging an entrenched group of Humans? What were they, idiots? They’d clearly counted on overwhelming the Humans in one push, but they’d underestimated the Gold-rank adventurer and the difficulty of overcoming the barricades. By himself, the warrior in silver armor had slain countless Goblins already and so long as he stood, the Goblins couldn’t advance past his position.

Too, the undead were complicating matters. Badarrow pointed and the Goblins saw the undead were attacking Goblins from behind, forcing them to split their forces. Something was moving the undead like a [Tactician], and it was making the attacking force’s job that much harder.

Still, all the Redfang Goblins could tell the battle was going one way. The zombies were getting diced by the Goblins for all the damage they

inflicted. The same could not be said of the inexperienced Human defenders. Worn down by both sides, the barricades were failing. Once one collapsed—

All the Humans would die. The Redfang warriors weren't sure how they felt about this. On one hand, Humans were usually their enemies. On the other hand, the Goblin Lords' forces were *definitely* their enemy. And besides—

They glanced left, at the young woman sitting next to them. She crouched on the roof, staring down at the battle.

She was Human, wasn't she? More and more Human, or so they felt. Headscratcher was sitting next to the Human and none of the Goblin warriors knew what to say. All they knew was they loved her. A tiny bit. For saving Grunter. For daring to hug a Goblin. For being like them.

A lot, actually. They loved her a lot, in the simple way they could. Because she didn't look at them like monsters. They'd never known they wanted that until this moment.

And she was staring at the battlefield. Grunter nudged her and grunted. He pointed towards the gates, undefended. She could run. The Redfang warriors should have left long ago. But the Human girl just stared at the battlements.

The Goblins were pressing in. Too deep to be pushed back and there weren't enough Humans on the side furthest from the adventurer. And there were too many undead. The Redfang warriors could see a familiar skeleton among the zombies and they wondered—

“Go.”

The word came from Headscratcher. It made the other Redfang warriors stiffen in shock, but he was pointing at the gates. He was urging the Human to go. To leave.

With them?

It was just a thought, a passing moment. The Human—the girl who was part monster—looked at Headscratcher, and hesitated. Then she shook her head slowly.

She pointed at the battlefield, at the Humans on the walls they had built. Faltering. Falling back. The monster pointed at them and touched her heart.

Some things didn't need words. The Goblins understood. But then she pointed at them, and at the Goblins and undead. She touched Headscratcher's sword, sheathed at his waist.

They stared at her. What did she mean? Grunter lowered his head as he understood, but the others didn't get it. The young woman wearing a monster's skin pointed again, at the backs of the undead, at the Goblins. She touched the sword and then her heart.

And they understood. She wanted them to help. To save...

Badarrow was the first to move. He shook his head and made a displeased noise. He stared at the battlefield as the other Goblins shuffled and looked down. The Redfang warriors looked at their feet, at the sky, at the battlefield, but none dared look at the monster who pleaded with them with her eyes.

Headscratcher looked away. He couldn't meet the young woman's eyes. He looked down.

How could they tell her? The Redfang warriors had no words to explain this. But it was easy enough that even the untrained monster girl could understand.

They were thirteen. Brave warriors, and good fighters, yes, but only thirteen. The army of the Goblin Lord was just that. An *army*. And the undead alone seemed limitless.

They were no heroes. And they weren't willing to die. In the end, they were still Goblins. And only a fool would go down there.

But they couldn't say it. Not to the girl who looked at them as if they were heroes. They couldn't bear to see the disappointment in her eyes.

None of them dared look up. Grunter touched his broken arm and stared at the man in silver armor. He fought on, a lone patch of flashing light amidst the dark armor and shambling bodies.

They weren't the same, in the end. A Goblin was still a Goblin. Not an adventurer.

The monster stared at the Goblins silently. They didn't see what was in her eyes, but they all saw her turn to look at the barricades. The Humans were being pressed back. The zombies were climbing as well, commanded by the skeleton no doubt. And with the Goblins attacking as well—

It would be over soon. Then they would have to leave. But what would the girl do? Could she survive like them? Could she come with them?

It was just a thought. But they saw it in Headscratcher's eyes. He wanted that. But the girl was different. She looked back at her people, dying, fighting, and touched her heart. They could not know it, but the young woman could hear it beating, so loudly she thought it might burst.

That was all. She just heard her heart beating in her chest. But she had nearly forgotten the sound. It reminded her of who she was.

It reminded her that she was Human.

The monster stood up. The Redfang warriors watched her silently. Slowly, she pointed towards the Humans and drew one line down her cheek. And touched her heart.

That was all. She bent, and Headscratcher looked up at her, full of—

She kissed him. Not on the lips, but gently on the cheek. He went still in shock and she smiled at him.

“Not a monster.”

Did she really whisper those words? Or was it only their imagination? Thirteen Goblins stared at her in silence. Then the monster—the young woman who wore a monster’s form—leapt. She flew through the air and landed on the ground, not even noticing the impact. She ran on all fours towards the battlefield, and it was a monster that crashed into the Goblins, tearing at them, biting, *slashing* as they cried out in horror and shock.

Headscratcher stood poleaxed in place, staring at her. But then he leapt from the rooftop, ignoring Grunter’s shout. He ran after her, chasing the young woman into the heart of the battlefield. And all twelve of the Redfang warriors were hot on his heels.

This is the story of a war. It was hot and brutal and oh so quick, and the living seemed to become the dead in the blink of an eye. But it was fought in a desolate city in the heart of winter.

Cold skies, snow on the ground. But hot bodies.

And blood. Tearing flesh. The monster swept through the ranks of Goblins besieging a barricade that had been partially knocked down. They saw her and cried out. Monsters, fearing a monster.

Her claws were razors that cut steel. Her teeth ripped away flesh and bone. The Goblins wearing black armor tried to cut at her, but she was a blur, and their weapons barely cut her thick skin.

This is the story of a young woman who let the monster in her out. She tore and bit and forgot fear and killed. She walked deeper down the path to hell, but she had a lifeline, a fragile thread that she held onto. A memory of a Goblin that hugged her, and a group of monsters with the hearts of heroes.

This is the story of a band of Goblins. They stood at the edge of death's gate, staring at the young woman who danced with the reaper, fearless, fighting for her people. Fighting to live. Fighting to be Human.

They hesitated. Their weapons were drawn, but they dared not plunge into the conflict. Because they were afraid. Because they wanted to live. They saw the other Goblins fall back in disarray and the Humans rally as the monster attacked them. But it was not enough. There were many Goblins, and this was only a corner of the battle.

And the undead were everywhere. They kept coming, and they kept attacking, slowly encircling both Humans and Goblins alike. They were commanded by that awful intelligence, the gleeful, mocking skeleton dancing in their midst.

The Goblins stared at the skeleton, not a hundred paces away but surrounded by his minions. And they knew that if he was not stopped the Humans would die.

On the skeleton all things turned. And then Grunter pointed.

There. The Goblin commander, silver halberd on hand, pointing as he rode his Shield Spider. He'd clashed with the Gold-rank adventurer, broken the lines of Humans again and again. Without him, the Goblins would be leaderless.

Two leaders. Headscratcher saw both as he held his sword in one sweaty claw. If one or both fell, the Humans would be saved. She might be saved. If they fought—

But his feet didn't move. Headscratcher stood where he was, ashamed. He shook. He was afraid to die. Because it would be certain death. And he was just a Goblin.

But the girl—she was a monster. She was a Human. She was something else. And she had seen the same thing the Goblins had. So she just ran. She leapt, and bore a Ghoul to the ground. Teeth gleamed and bit and the two creatures tore at each other.

Headscratcher shouted and ran forwards, sword raised as Badarrow tried to find a target among the blurring shapes. But then the Ghoul was down, a gaping hole in his throat and neck. The monster-girl ran on, at the mass of zombies shielding the skeleton.

And stumbled.

And fell.

Because of the arrow in her back.

Headscratcher screamed. He saw the shaft strike the young woman—not from the sides, but from above. A shot from high up on the barricades.

A Human had loosed the arrow. Perhaps he had mistaken the young woman for a Ghoul—or perhaps he had just seen what she'd looked like and shot. But the arrow had struck the young woman all the same.

She fell, and the zombies she'd been running towards surrounded her, biting. Tearing. Headscratcher ran into them, slashing wildly. Two zombies fell as he ran them through, shoving them aside. An arrow killed a third and then the other Redfang warriors were around him. They forced the zombies back as Headscratcher held the young woman in his arms.

He reached for the arrow and stopped. It was too deep, and the monster in his arms—

Was no monster. She was just a young woman, bleeding, torn.

Dying. She blinked up at the Goblin who held her, and wondered why she'd never imagined a Goblin could cry. Of course they could. It was such a simple thing, but it just proved her point.

They were people too.

She reached up and tried to brush the tear from Headscratcher's eyes. But she was too weak. Her arm flopped back and the young woman coughed. She blinked down at the blood in astonishment.

Around her, the other Goblins were tearing at their packs, searching their belts. But they had no potions. Just the one they'd used for Grunter. The Hobgoblin knelt next to the girl, staring at her.

She smiled at them. Weakly. Dying. But then her head rose, and she stared at the Humans. They were so very fragile, so alone.

She pointed. The Goblins looked. The young woman touched her heart, once. It was still beating, slowly. That was all. She touched her heart and drew a line in blood down her cheek.

Asking a question no words could ever say.

This is the story of a Goblin who held a dying Human in his arms. The other warriors stood shoulder-to-shoulder, shields raised, protecting her from the few arrows that flew towards them. They snarled at the Humans on the barricades, watching as the undead pushed them further and further back.

The Goblin held the Human in his arms, staring at death. It was all around him, and in the burning purple eyes of the skeleton surrounded by the undead. He stared at death, but he only had eyes for the Human.

She spoke to him, words that he and all the Goblins heard, even amidst the fighting. The Goblin listened, head bowed, until she choked on the blood and he carried her away from the fighting, protected by his friends.

He laid her in a quiet place, away from the battlefield. Next to a dying fire in a place where she would be safe. Then the Goblin turned back and stared at death. Beside him, twelve other Goblins stood quietly. They looked at each other. And heard their hearts beating.

This is the story of a band of fools. They charged, screaming, at an army of thousands. Goblins and undead both turned to stare at them, and the Humans on the walls stopped firing as they saw the band of thirteen Goblins, fighting for something they didn't quite understand.

Headscratcher was first. He ran, cutting wildly, knocking other warriors aside, darting past zombies. He didn't care that they cut at him, ignored the arrows that flew at him, the moments when he stared death in the face. He only had eyes for the skeleton, standing among the zombies.

He ran, and ten Goblins followed his back, fighting as one, struggling for every step. But two Goblins did not follow them. One was Badarrow, who stood with an arrow nocked, firing into the mill of bodies. The other was Grunter.

Grunter. The Hobgoblin turned and ran in another direction. Away? The other Redfang warriors faltered. But the Hob turned and stared at them for one moment. Then he spoke.

“Go.”

One word. And then he plunged away through the mass of bodies. He didn't dodge like Headscratcher. Instead, Grunter charged *through* the ranks of undead and Goblin alike. Zombies were hurled away from him, screaming Goblin warriors trampled underfoot. Grunter held his axe in his left hand and roared as he ran.

He had only one target. The Goblin commander astride his Shield Spider. At first, the other Goblin didn't see Grunter among the Goblins. But soon the Goblin noticed the change in the battlefield.

In a sea of swirling fighting where the lines of black-armored Goblins and zombies pushed each other back and forth, Grunter cut a straight line to the Goblin commander. He couldn't be stopped! Spears broke against his skin, swords cut but were wrenched away from their owner's grip. Grunter ran on, bleeding from two dozen wounds, but still ran.

“*You! Challenge!*”

The word was a roar from Grunter's mouth. The Goblins and Humans stopped fighting as they stared at the Hob charging at the other Goblin. The Goblin commander sneered. He raised a hand; pointed.

Another Hob, just as large as Grunter, ran forwards, screaming, sword in hand as he tried to slow the Redfang warrior's advance. Grunter *roared* and swung his axe. The crushing blade crashed down even as the other Hob tried to block. The axe sheared through the sword and crushed the other Goblin's head. Grunter wrenched the blade free and the Hob's body fell.

Silence. Grunter raised his axe, gleaming with blood and gore.

"Redfang!"

It was a word none of the Humans knew. But among the Goblins, it caused silence. Who didn't know of that famous tribe, of the warrior who had walked among other races?

Garen Redfang and his tribe of warriors. Even in the south, his name was legend. Grunter shouted again, pointing his axe at the Goblin commander.

Now the other Goblin hissed, his eyes flashing blood-red. He pulled his spider around and faced Grunter. The other Goblins fell away as the two ran at each other, the Hob bleeding, one arm raised with the axe, the gleaming halberd held in the other Goblin's hand.

"Redfang!"

Grunter screamed as he brought the axe down. The blow cleaved through the air, unstoppable. The Goblin commander threw himself off of his mount's back, and the blow smashed the giant Shield Spider into the ground. It shrieked and died.

But it had taken Grunter's axe. The Hob pulled at the blade, trying to wrench it free, but too slowly. The halberd came up and then the Hob was stumbling back. He stared at his stump of a hand and heard the Goblin commander laugh. The other Goblin advanced towards him, halberd raised.

The Hob was still for a second. Then his other hand moved. His broken arm grabbed the axe and lifted it. Jagged yellow bone broke through Grunter's skin, but he only grunted. Then the axe was in the air.

The Goblin commander raised his halberd, snarling, but too slow. The axe fell through the sky, changing the confidence to fear in the Goblin's eyes. Grunter screamed.

"REDFANG!"

The blow shook the earth. It broke his arm completely. Bone and flesh splintered as his hand twisted, dangling uselessly from his arm. Grunter sat down, staring at his useless arms as the other Goblins and Humans stared at what remained of the Goblin commander, the halberd lying broken on the ground.

The black-armored Goblins hesitated. But then they rushed at Grunter, screaming. He stood and knocked one down with his bloody stump. He kicked another hard enough to break the Goblin's bones. Then he was falling, pierced by countless blades.

Grunter lay down on the ground and stared at his own blood. With a great effort he turned onto his back and stared at the grey sky. He grunted. And smiled once before the Goblins covered him.

Badarrow saw Grunter fall. He screamed and shot the Goblin who'd killed him. But there were so many. And the Goblins saw him, saw the Goblin shooting at their friends.

Arrows flew towards Badarrow, hundreds of them. Like rain. He dove for cover behind a fat corpse, letting it absorb the deadly arrows. So many.

The Goblin commander was dead, and so the Goblins were faltering. But there were still others, weren't there? Badarrow had seen them, two [Shamans] hiding behind the others, commanding a group of undead they'd managed to gain control of.

They had to die. For Grunter. For using the dead. Badarrow didn't hesitate. He selected two arrows, his very best. The ones he knew would fly furthest, straightest. He stood from behind the corpse and drew the first arrow to his chest. He loosed it.

The arrow flew across the battlefield. It caught the first [Shaman] as he stood behind a group of zombies, pointing and laughing. He grasped the arrow as it sprouted from his chest and fell, gasping.

The other [Shaman] pointed and screamed. He turned to run, and the second arrow found his ear. Badarrow grinned, and laughed as he saw the other Goblins turning. This time there was nowhere to hide.

So many arrows. Like rain! They struck him, one finding his chest, another his leg, the last his shoulder. Badarrow stumbled and fell.

Headscratcher did not see either of his friends fall. He ran on, sword drawn, screaming. The zombies were everywhere, as were the black-armored Goblins. He cut at them.

Too many enemies. Then a zombie came swinging at Headscratcher from the right, five more on the left. Headscratcher saw another Goblin run past him. Rocksoup took the blows meant for him. He gasped as the zombies tore his flesh away, cut one down. Two. The third took his sword and then he was fighting with his hands against the other two. They bore him down as he stared at Headscratcher, mouthing silently as his eyes lost their light.

Telling him to run.

The ten Goblins ran on, not pausing as they left their friend behind. Leftstep was next to fall. An arrow caught him in the eye and he dropped soundlessly, still snarling.

Headscratcher cut the head off of a Goblin and saw the skeleton. Only forty paces ahead now. It still hadn't seen them. He ran towards it, but a group of howling Goblins charged from the right.

Orangepoo ran forwards. He said not a word, just grinned like he always did. Headscratcher saw him fall as he buried a spear in one of the Goblins' legs and trip up the rest.

Eight now. The Goblin warriors ran on. Now the skeleton had seen them, and it pointed. Zombies and even a Ghoul came for them. Bitefly fell on the right, cursing and cutting at the Ghoul as it bore him to the ground and tore at him.

Seven. There was a wall of undead in front of them. Headscratcher and the Redfang warriors charged into them, screaming. The skeleton was right in front of them. And he had a sword.

Cut them down. Headscratcher took the leading zombie down with a leaping thrust. He fell with the body, struggling to pull his sword free. The other Redfang warriors took down their targets too. Where was the skeleton?

A flash of movement. Headscratcher saw Patchhelm turn and then the skeleton blurred into focus. The Goblin fell, headless. Headscratcher *screamed* and charged the skeleton.

So close. The skeleton fell back, fighting four of the Redfang warriors at once. But more zombies were coming, running at them. One seized Justrust from behind and snapped his neck.

Five. The five cut at the skeleton, making him dodge backwards. But he was all bones and he didn't fear mere cuts. Headscratcher took a cut that laid open his leg and he saw Rabbiteater choke as a zombie bit him all the way down to the bone, making him drop the sword.

The skeleton laughed. He turned to run, mocking the Goblins who'd come to kill him. Headscratcher swung at him as the skeleton danced backwards, nimbly evading his sword thrust.

So close! But not enough. The skeleton's purple flaming eyes glittered at Headscratcher. He stepped left, dodged a thrust, flicked his sword and parried a cut. He raised his own sword as Headscratcher stumbled, seized by a zombie on his left. The skeleton laughed—

And Shorthilt tackled him from behind. The skeleton stumbled, turned, tried to kick the Goblin off. But Shorthilt hung on, ignoring the foot that kicked his face and broke his nose. Bugear cut sideways, forcing the skeleton to block. Then the Goblin cut at the skeleton's sword hand, deep, lodging his sword into the skeleton's bones. Bugear strained to keep the skeleton's arm in place as Headscratcher ran forwards. The skeleton turned towards him, eyes furious.

Yes. That was right. It wasn't fair. It wasn't honorable. But it was the way the Goblins fought. And Headscratcher's sword cleaved the skeleton's spine in two. The skeleton fell in two pieces, and the Redfang warriors broke apart his body with their weapons.

Around them, the undead—paused. They seemed to stare at nothing, and then they moved again. Still attacking. Still trying to kill the living.

But no longer intelligently. No longer moving with purpose. The Redfang warriors, the five survivors, stumbled away. Headscratcher abandoned his sword to pull Rabbiteater away, giving the Goblin his shoulder.

They ran. Goblins were still everywhere. And the undead too. But they'd done all they could. All they could.

And it was enough. Because as the Goblins launched a final, desperate attack on the Humans on the barricades, the Redfang warriors looked to the gates of the city. And there they saw the adventurers.

“We barely made it by the looks of it.”

That was what the half-Elf said to the Dwarf as they stood at the rear of the Goblin army. Without their commander, the Goblins had neglected their rear. Now they rushed to overwhelm the Human defenders, stretched too thin on their crumbling fortifications.

“That’s true. But we did get here, and we even brought help.”

So said the Dwarf. He was short for a Human, naturally, but those Humans who saw him tended to think he was tall for a Dwarf. He was not, at least, not for a modern Dwarf. He was five foot two, and his muscles rippled as he raised the hammer at his side.

Behind him, a group of men and women, all Humans, stood with their weapons drawn. Silver-rank adventurers, over twenty of them. The half-Elf nodded.

“Let’s go. I’ll begin—hit them from the sides and cut towards Ylawes, would you?”

“Aye. Leave it to me.”

The Dwarf grinned. He turned his voice and roared at the Silver-rank adventurers.

“Follow me!”

He lead the host of [Warriors], [Mages], [Archers], [Rogues], and more at the side of the Goblin host, smashing through their unguarded ranks with ease. Even the Hob who turned to fight was crushed by a blow from the Dwarf’s hammer.

Alone, the half-Elf faced the Goblins who’d become aware of her presence. She raised the staff at her side, the blue crystal embedded in it shining. Arrows flew towards her, but the [Mage] was undeterred. She pointed at the Goblins.

“[Windward], [Flashfire], [Lesser Twister], [Water Arrow], [Silent Sickle], [Muddy Ground]—”

The litany of spells blasted from her staff, countless spells blasting Goblins off their feet, showering others with rains of arrows made from water, cutting others to bits while the arrows that had flown at the half-Elf bounced off the shield of air she’d conjured.

The battlefield changed again. The Silver-rank adventurers and Gold-rank Dwarf cut towards the stunned Humans. The Bronze-rank adventurer

with a sword clutched at Ylawes as the man stumbled, nearly collapsing amid the walls of bodies he'd slain.

"Who are they sir? Reinforcements? From which city?"

"Yes. From all the nearby cities. And the Dwarf and half-Elf. They're my team. The Silver Swords."

Disbelieving, the Humans on the barricades stared as the Goblins below them began to rout. Their leaders lost, attacked by so many powerful adventurers, they began to flee. The undead kept fighting, but they were fragmented.

The exhausted man in silver armor raised his head as he heard the cheering begin. He didn't smile. The man next to him turned to him, face shining.

"You saved us! You did it! We did it! We beat the Goblins by ourselves."

"No. I don't think it was just that."

Ylawes didn't look at the confused man. His eyes found the group of Goblins, five now, injured, fleeing the battle. The adventurer sighed, and then sat down.

He was so tired.

He was so *angry*. Toren strode away from the battlefield, knowing all was lost. He couldn't change the outcome now. The zombies were no match for adventurers of that caliber. And he'd been so close too! Just a few more moments and he would have broken the line of Humans and been able to finish off the human in silver armor!

So close! But the Goblins had messed everything up!

Enraged, Toren slashed at the air with his sword, close to exploding with fury. How dare they. How *dare* they? They hadn't even fought fair! They'd fought—well, like he fought!

It wasn't fair. It wasn't right. Toren stopped by the door of an abandoned building, trying to think rationally. He had to escape now. He still had his levels, his life. He could get some undead and go. Start somewhere else.

Doing what? The skeleton kicked at the wall and paused. Did he hear something? Cautiously, he poked his head inside the building. That was

when he saw her.

A Human, lying on the ground. Toren hesitated. He...thought she was a Human. But didn't he recognize her somewhere?

The monster girl. Yes. The flames in Toren's eyes brightened in shock. But she was different. Was she wounded?

Yes. She was barely clinging to life. The skeleton walked over to her and saw the Human's lips moving. She was whispering—something.

He didn't care. The skeleton raised his sword and thrust it into the young woman's side. He needed to kill something to feel better. He stabbed the Human with his sword, relishing the way she cried out weakly.

And then Toren heard the shout. He turned, but too late. The blow knocked him backwards. A Goblin had charged him from the side! The Goblin had no weapon and he struggled with Toren for his blade.

The skeleton tried to stab the Goblin, but he had been caught off-guard. His own sword impaled him through the rib cage. Toren staggered away, outraged, trying to drag the blade free. At last he got it out, splintering his bones in the process. He turned, sword in hand, and saw the Goblin.

He was holding the Human in his arms. She bled onto the ground, life oozing around his desperate claws. But she was...smiling. Smiling?

Toren paused.

He stared at the Goblin as he held the young woman in his arms, clutching at her bleeding chest, trying to hold the blood in. The skeleton saw a hand come up, and hold the Goblin's face, and saw bloodless lips move. He saw the Goblin's tears and felt something...odd in his chest.

What was this? What was he seeing? Goblin and Human? Why did that strike him as so odd? So—

Special? Was that the word? But the moment passed even as the skeleton watched. The Human's hand dropped and her body relaxed. But her smile remained. And the Goblin holding her wept.

Toren looked away. He didn't attack the weeping Goblin. Instead, he slowly walked into an alley as the other Goblin warriors ran to the two, crying out, making sounds of—

He didn't understand. So he walked away, leaving the Goblins behind.

This is the story of a monster. This is the story of monsters. For as Ylawes stood with his companions and the celebrating Humans, he heard a cry.

“Goblins!”

He turned, reaching exhausted for a sword, but called out when he saw the approaching Goblins. They’d been poised to run, but as Ylawes strode towards them they halted.

Arrows and spells were aimed at them but the Goblins just looked lost. Four were holding the body between them and the last just stared up at Ylawes as he approached. He halted when he saw the young woman’s body, the face he recognized.

“Is she...?”

The Goblin nodded. He stared up at Ylawes, and the adventurer looked down at the dead girl. Her face had been ravaged by famine, and dirt and filth had created a mask over her face. But she smiled. It was a simple expression, but it shone even in death, despite all she had endured.

Ylawes remembered seeing her before. He remembered a monster. But what he saw was a young woman, smiling upwards. Only that.

Slowly, the adventurer looked at the Goblins. They stared back at him. Silent.

“I saw your leader kill the Goblin commander.”

Silence.

“I saw your archer down the [Shamans]. Few Human [Archers] I know could do that.”

They just stared at him. Ylawes nodded at the Goblin in front.

“You slew the skeleton. Without that, we might have died before reinforcements could arrive.”

Slowly, the Goblins laid down the body of the Human girl on the ground. They ignored Ylawes completely. One of the Goblins with a bloody scalp slowly crossed the young woman’s arms over her chest. He hesitated, hand on hers. Then he turned away.

“May we never meet again.”

Ylawes called it at their backs. But the Goblins didn’t even acknowledge his presence. They just walked away.

They found Grunter before they left. There wasn't much of the Hob, but the Redfang warriors gathered around his corpse for a moment. Then they walked on.

They found Badarrow, laughing, shaking as he sat amid the arrows that had nearly killed him. Three arrows had found him, but the one meant for his chest had been horribly made. The glue had broken off and the arrowhead had barely penetrated his skin. He was still laughing about how he'd never hate another arrow when they found him.

Then Badarrow just bowed his head. He stood up and looked towards the body, but the other Humans were around her. The Redfang warriors slowly walked out of the city, avoiding the undead.

Silent.

This is a story of a band of Goblins, and how they left a city behind them as they walked out into the snow and darkness. They left behind their leader, over half their number and a Human girl in the city. And they left something as well. Perhaps it was a bit of their hearts.

This is the story of monsters. Of Goblins. But they had names.

Rabbiteater.

Bugear.

Numbtongue.

Shorthilt.

Badarrow.

Headscratcher.

This is their story. This is the story of how they found and left Esthelm, a city of the desperate, the dead, and those who struggled even in the darkness. This is their story. This is how it began.

This is the story of a skeleton. He walked away from the city whose name he hadn't even known, beaten. Defeated not just by swords and sorcery, but by something he didn't even have a name for.

He walked away, not alone physically, but alone nevertheless. Thirteen zombies and a Ghoul walked with him, silent, unthinking. They were tools, that was all. And Toren realized that a tool was not enough. Killing was not enough.

He was alone, purposeless again. He had failed. Toren walked on, staring at the sky. And he began to realize there were still some things he didn't understand in this world. So he left the city where the living had reclaimed their pride. He left the Goblins, the adventurer wearing silver armor, and the monster who had become a girl behind.

And the dead walked with him.

To Liscor.

Back home.

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3.21 L

Pawn stared at the ranks of Soldiers under his command and realized that he'd made a mistake.

Somewhere.

He'd definitely made one a while back, when he'd brought the idea of Gods into the Hive of the Free Antinium in Liscor. That had been a mistake—or at least, telling the Soldiers had been.

Hadn't it?

It had helped them. Pawn had thought it would save them, but it had only led to a terrible moment where they slaughtered each other to find a better place. He'd stopped that—

But at a terrible cost. Nearly an entire barracks' worth of Soldiers had been injured, and hundreds had died. Still, many had been saved, and Pawn had realized what his true mission was that day. To make a Heaven for the Antinium. To make a place, a way that they would not die forgotten and alone.

And he had leveled up after that night, hadn't he? He was now a Level 6 [Acolyte] with the Skill [Humble Presence], which was surely a boon to the Hive. And Klbkch had given him command of the remaining Soldiers—

Perhaps that was the mistake. Revalantor Klbkch had made the mistake here, because Pawn was sure of one thing. He couldn't lead the Soldiers.

He had no idea how.

Pawn stared down at the ranks of silent, immobile giants aligned into perfect ranks in front of him. The Soldiers stood patiently, waiting for his command. Perhaps they would wait there forever, even if he left.

Such thoughts were terrifying to Pawn. He was no leader. Except, in a very real sense, he was. Moreover, those under his command needed him. If nothing else, Pawn had to ensure they didn't die of their injuries.

Yes, every Soldier standing at attention was technically walking—or rather, standing—wounded. Of course they didn't show any signs of pain, despite some having cracked carapaces or missing limbs. One Soldier was missing his right eye, but he looked at Pawn as if nothing was wrong.

At least...they were here with him, rather than fighting as they would be normally. Even though the Soldiers here were injured, Pawn knew that they

would still have normally been assigned to combat duty if it weren't for him.

The most wounded Soldier could fight after only a few days of rest. Of course, they'd be missing limbs but that didn't matter when they hurled themselves into combat. Pawn had requested the foul, stinging ooze to begin regenerating their body parts, but it was a precious commodity and so the Soldiers would be weeks or even months in regrowing their limbs.

And in the meantime, what did Pawn do? He stared at his Soldiers, and they stared back. He couldn't send them to battle. He couldn't.

And yet, they were his responsibility. He had to make something of them. That was what Klbkch had told him. This was a test—

And Pawn had no idea how to pass it. He was pretty sure on how to fail, but what could he do with the Soldiers? All he had done was give them false hope—

And get a lot of them killed.

Pawn shook his head and the Soldiers seemed to straighten even more. It had been five minutes since he'd entered the mess hall and found the Soldiers waiting for him. He had to give them an order, he knew. They needed direction.

Hesitantly, the Worker cleared his throat.

"You will not be expected to fight today."

The Soldiers just stared at him. Did they feel relieved? Disappointed? Confused? Pawn didn't know. Their faces were as incomprehensible to him as all Antinium were to other species. But he knew they did have feelings.

"Um...just go about your daily routine. That is to say—"

Pawn paused. He had to be a leader. So he firmed his tone.

"Attend meal times as normal. However, since you are not assigned to any post, return to your barracks to rest in the meantime. I will...find something for you to do, and try to visit you and tell stories. Alright?"

The Soldiers didn't respond. But they turned and immediately began filing out of the room, heading towards the barracks. Pawn watched them go, limp with relief.

At least they listened to him. But did they resent him for telling them about God and Heaven? Did they feel regret for their brothers that had died in the mass suicide attempt?

Surely they did. But Pawn couldn't ask, because the Soldiers couldn't speak. The Worker anxiously paced back and forth as the other Workers

assigned to food serving duty watched him nervously. He was commanding Soldiers. Pawn knew they would fight the monsters that came out of the dungeon and patrol and guard—but was there anything else they did?

He'd never known. And now he had to ask. But who would be able to tell him?

Not other Workers. Klbkch perhaps—but Pawn didn't feel comfortable asking the Revalantor questions like that. Who else might know?

The Queen? Pawn would have rather slapped Klbkch than ask his Queen anything. No. No, there were only two other beings in the Hive who might know.

Belgrade and Anand. They were [Tacticians]. They'd leveled up in that class and been assigned roles leading Soldiers. They would know.

Pawn found his two former chess companions after only half an hour of searching. It wasn't as if Belgrade and Anand left signs pointing out their location in the Hive, but Pawn knew where they ate and slept. Happily, he found them doing neither and instead, playing chess in the special break room reserved for Individuals.

The two Workers sat at a chess table, watched by a small crowd of other Workers. They stood out. Perhaps it was the way they held themselves. With confidence and pride. Or maybe it was just that Pawn knew them so well. He sat next to them and they nodded at him, familiar and warm as the Antinium ever got.

"Pawn. It is good to see you here today."

That came from Belgrade. He nodded precisely as he placed a knight in the attack position, threatening a pawn from Anand.

"Indeed. I was worried you were being punished by Klbkch."

Anand ignored the attack on his pawns and instead countered Belgrade with an aggressive push from his queen on the left side, threatening a bishop. Belgrade paused. Pawn observed the playing with interest, his mind half on the game.

It was true that he, Belgrade, and Anand all looked the same. But they were all different from each other—vastly different in terms of personality. Belgrade was a stickler for tactics and the openings Erin had taught them. He played defensively, cautiously. Almost too much, but it was necessary against Anand's aggressive tactics. In speech as well, they tended to reflect their traits. It was remarkable, Pawn reflected, that any Workers could be so...unique.

He nodded to the two as the game continued, both Workers moving their pieces quickly and only pausing for a few seconds even for the hardest decisions. They were clearly playing a lightning game, although there was no timer. Antinium had no need of such devices.

“I thank you for your concern. I am not being punished by Revalantor Klbkch, Anand. But I am in distress.”

“Indeed?”

“What’s the problem?”

“You may be aware that I have been assigned a command of Soldiers. I am unsure how to properly lead them, and what roles they may fulfill within the Hive. Thus, I have come to you.”

The Antinium also didn’t do much small talk. Belgrade and Anand paused for a moment. Then Belgrade tipped over his king.

“I cannot win this match. Another round?”

“Yes.”

The two reset the board, moving pieces with amazing synchronization. Pawn waited patiently. The game began with a classic King’s Gambit Accepted opening before Anand spoke.

“My experience with leading Soldiers occurs mainly in embattled tunnels and areas of the Hive in which conflict occurs. I direct their movements, reinforce them with Skills, and order retreats and designate targets as necessary.”

“That is my experience as well.”

Belgrade nodded. He placed a knight on the board delicately and stopped. Pawn had observed that Belgrade liked using knight pieces to open with.

“I have supervised Soldiers aiding in digging and construction at times. But Workers are more suited to those tasks. Patrolling, fighting, guarding, and scouting are the only roles I have seen them fulfill.”

Pawn felt his antennae droop. But he hadn’t really expected anything else.

“I see. And you have not ever seen them do anything for—for entertainment?”

Both of the other Workers paused and turned to Pawn. He knew they were surprised. If they had eyebrows, they would have been raising them.

“The Antinium have no entertainment.”

“Nor any other form of leisurely activity. This game of chess is as close as we have to it.”

“I know. It is just—I wish to give the Soldiers something more. You are aware of the details surrounding their injuries?”

“I am.”

“It was your fault, correct?”

Pawn nodded at Anand, acknowledging the truth.

“Yes. I regret my stupidity. And yet, I must now lead them. But I am no leader, no [Tactician] as you two are. You have continued to level. May I ask what level you are now?”

“Fifteen.”

Belgrade adjusted a piece on the crude board, meticulously centering it in the square before he moved it.

“Sixteen.”

Anand waited until the piece had moved to swiftly take it with a bishop. Belgrade made no audible response, but Pawn knew he was annoyed at making such a simple mistake.

“I am now a Level 6 [Acolyte].”

“Indeed? Congratulations are in order for such swift advancement.”

Belgrade and Anand turned. Both nodded at Pawn. He nodded back, feeling happy for their praise.

“It is just that I fail to see how my class can help the Soldiers. I barely know what to do with myself.”

“Perhaps Revalantor Klbkch sees something in you that cannot be defined by your class.”

Anand speculated as Belgrade attempted to regain lost ground. Pawn nodded slowly. He looked around at the other Workers.

They just stared at the board. He knew they were listening, but the other Workers—Individuals and Workers groomed to be Individuals—they had no spark. Not like Belgrade, Anand, Garry, and Bird. Those four Workers had what Pawn considered personality. The other Workers in the room were more like statues.

Soulless.

That was the word for it. It disturbed Pawn, although he couldn’t say why. Were the Soldiers like that? In a way, yes. Both they and the Workers kept their feelings, their true selves on the inside, if they even had a self at

all. What could Pawn do for them, besides send them to die? What could he —?

“Pawn. Revalantor Klbkch approaches.”

Belgrade looked up and Pawn turned in his seat. The other Workers standing around the board scattered to make lots of room for the slim, unique Antinium as he marched quickly towards Pawn.

“Pawn.”

Just that one word made Pawn’s insides knot up. He hadn’t even known they could do that, but then, he’d seldom felt...trepidation before. But Klbkch scared him, and every time they met, Pawn couldn’t help but feel like he was doing everything wrong.

A feeling which was reinforced by Klbkch’s next words. The Revalantor stopped in front of him.

“Did you give your Soldiers orders this morning?”

Pawn cringed a bit. Was he not supposed to?

“Yes I did. Was anything—”

“They went back to their barracks and began to rest. They remained in the barracks when another shift came to rest, causing a delay.”

Oh no. Pawn’s insides twisted further, and he saw both Belgrade and Anand pause in playing chess. How could he have forgotten? The Antinium had no personal quarters—rather, they slept and worked and ate at allotted times, in shifts. When one shift slept, another one would work, and then the sleeping shift would switch with another one.

That was the most efficient use of resources and it meant places like the barracks could be used at all times. Pawn had—he’d ordered his Soldiers to take up the space meant for other exhausted Soldiers ending their shift!

The Antinium couldn’t blush, but Pawn lowered his head and antennae. He’d already messed up. And it was such a *stupid* mistake to make too!

“Forgive me, Revalantor Klbkch. I did not consider that when I gave my orders to the Soldiers. I am terribly—”

“I have taken care of it. Your Soldiers are being stationed in safe locations on protective detail. In the future do not make the same mistake.”

Klbkch’s voice was flat. He turned to go. Pawn looked at his back despairingly and called out.

“Revalantor Klbkch.”

The Antinium turned. He was graceful, deadly. He walked as if the two swords by his side were meant for him, and he never looked uncertain. How

Pawn envied him.

“What is it, Pawn?”

“What should I do with the Soldiers under my command? Am I to lead them into battle?”

“No. You have only a single Skill in the [Tactician] class and you are too valuable to risk in battle. Moreover, the Soldiers are wounded. Your command over them is experimental.”

“Then—what purpose will we serve?”

Klbgkch paused. He looked Pawn straight in the eye.

“I do not know. Surprise me. Or pray for an idea. That is your Skill, is it not?”

He turned and left. Belgrade and Anand stopped their game and watched him go. After a while, the other Workers walked back and resumed watching their game. Belgrade paused.

“I am unsure as to what you should do, Pawn. I regret that Erin is not here to aid you.”

“Indeed. I dislike Revalantor Klbgkch’s requirements of you, and the Revalantor himself if it comes to that. Checkmate.”

Anand placed his queen and created an excellent checkmate. Belgrade nodded. He looked at the other [Tactician].

“I am extremely upset, Anand. I demand a rematch.”

“I accept.”

Pawn left them to it. Well, he had his answer. He was supposed to do something with the Soldiers—only, even Klbgkch had no idea what. Wonderful.

That was how, terribly depressed, Pawn found himself walking through Liscor that evening. He was still free to leave the Hive, and so he walked among the Drakes and Gnolls, feeling the cold wind on his carapace.

No one paid any attention to him. Normally, they might, if only to look scared and walk away from him. But today Pawn was more invisible than anything else. Oh, people noticed him, but he was now simply another person in the crowd, rather than a Worker, an Antinium.

It was due to his new Skill. [Humble Presence]. It made him, well, ordinary unless Pawn did something that really stood out or he was by himself. It was perfect for someone like him. Klbgkch had already told him it might have useful applications in battle—but Pawn didn’t want to fight.

But he commanded Soldiers. But he had no idea what to do with them.

And he'd already caused trouble. Pawn hung his head, but his feet kept moving. In times like this, he only had one place he wanted to be.

The Wandering Inn. Even if Erin wasn't there, at least Pawn could rest there in peace for a while. And he was getting hungry. Pawn had begun to hate eating in the Hive, and he had money. So Pawn walked out of the city and up to the inn.

It was the only place where he really felt *alive*.

She had a guest. Lyonette rubbed her eyes a few times when she saw the figure slowly walking up the hill towards the empty inn. But it was real. Someone was coming.

A guest!

She nearly cried in relief. It had been...so long.

Two days this time. Two days after Lyonette had worked so hard! She'd made food and learned to cook and even cleaned the inn. But it had been two days since Pawn had left, and no one had come by.

Not Olesm, not Relc to ask about Erin, not even the grumpy adventurer. No one. But now she had a guest! The same guest, in fact, as last time.

The Antinium. Pawn. Lyonette remembered being afraid of him, of hating the Antinium. But right now she could have kissed the Worker on his mandibles. He was coming to spend money! To eat!

The girl rushed around the kitchen, trying to figure out what to make. Food! She couldn't serve him the rubbery noodles she'd been making herself for breakfast, lunch and dinner, could she?

No, the Antinium couldn't even handle gluten.

No bread or pasta, then. Lyonette froze. Could she make a soup? But when she checked, she had barely half a bucket of water left! And then the Antinium was at the door and there was no time to fetch more!

Screaming internally, Lyonette opened the door.

"Good evening!"

The Antinium entered, nodding politely at her.

"Good evening to you, Miss Lyonette. Are you open today?"

"Open? Of course! We're open every day! Every night! Let me get you a chair. Would you like to sit next to the fire? I can put more wood on—"

"Thank you."

Seemingly bemused, the Worker watched Lyonette rush about, stoking the fire, getting him a glass of water. She hovered around him anxiously, trying not to wring her hands.

“Would you like something else to drink? Um—we don’t have anything, though. To eat?”

“Water is quite acceptable, thank you. I would indeed like food tonight. What is on the menu, may I ask?”

Lyonette froze. What was on the menu? She didn’t even *have* a menu! Her mind went blank, but her mouth took over in this moment of crisis.

“W-would you like eggs and bacon?”

That was all she could think to make! Erin normally had all kinds of soups and meat dishes she could serve—but Lyonette didn’t know how to cook any of them!

Pawn seemed to think for a moment, and then nodded.

“Yes. I will have some, thank you.”

Lyonette smiled at him, dashed into the kitchen, and called herself ten kinds of stupid while she fried up a heaping plate for him. Eggs and bacon? She’d served that to him *last* time! He’d get bored of the food, surely! When she’d been living in the palace, Lyonette would have fired the [Chef] who made her the same meal twice in one week!

But the Antinium didn’t seem offended. Instead, he paused when Lyonette placed the big plate of eggs and bacon in front of him—nearly all of what she had left.

“This is quite a fine meal. Thank you.”

“You’re very welcome!”

Lyonette nearly sagged in relief. She hovered around Pawn as he picked up a fork. He paused, looked at her.

“Would you like to sit?”

“Oh!”

She was bothering him! Lyonette sat instantly, trying to smile and not be obtrusive as Pawn ate. The silence was...

After a few minutes Pawn spoke.

“It seems the inn is rather empty. Have you been receiving much custom, Miss Lyonette?”

“Me? No I—”

Lyonette paused. How could she tell the Antinium about crying in the inn, counting the few copper and two silver coins left? Eating the same

horrible mush she cooked up every day? How could she?

How could she not?

“It’s been...hard since Erin—Miss Solstice left. No one visits.”

“That is troublesome. I hope my business can help.”

“It will! I just wish there were a lot more people like—like you!”

“Thank you for the compliment.”

“You’re...welcome.”

More silence. Lyonette looked at Pawn, realizing this was the first time she’d ever been so close to one of the hateful Antinium, the terrors of Rhir. He looked so...normal for some reason.

“Um.”

“Yes?”

“How’s it going in the Hive? With the other Antinium, I mean?”

The Worker seemed to pause for a few seconds.

“It is...going well. There are some difficulties, but the Hive is well.”

“Good.”

“Yes.”

Lyonette sat with the Worker, refilling his glass, drinking some water herself. They didn’t talk much while he ate his way through the plate of greasy eggs and bacon. When he left, he paid her well. Lyonette stared at the bronze coins and smiled tremulously. Then she cried again.

Pawn left The Wandering Inn in good spirits. The brief respite and dinner made for a world of difference. Suddenly, he felt happy again.

The inn. Sitting there and talking—well, it wasn’t the same, but the Human girl had been decent company and the food had been far better than the mush in the Hive.

A good night. A good evening. That was what it was. Pawn walked back down the hill, staring up at the clear night sky as he did. The air was cold around him, but he enjoyed the biting chill and the crisp *crunching* sound the snow made under his feet.

The stars. Oh, how the stars shone. Yellow and red some of them, but green and purple others, shining bright, shining faintly, some flickering behind the occasional cloud. And the two moons were beautiful as well.

A sky full of wonders, a landscape full of snow and silence. Warm belly, good conversation. Pawn felt alive again. This was what he'd missed.

How wonderful. How...Pawn stopped in the snow, struck by a sudden realization.

"This is what I must show them."

Yes. *This*. This night was like everything Pawn had experienced since meeting Erin, a small capsule of pure happiness. Of course, the inn was different, and it had been Erin, not Lyonette running it. But it had been the experiences of the inn which had made Pawn who he was. Klbkch desired new Individuals, but just teaching them chess wasn't enough. Chess was only the method. It had been Erin who truly mattered.

And if she was gone, then it fell to Pawn to show the Soldiers the same world she had shown him. Pawn walked back to his Hive, his steps suddenly full of purpose. He needed to take his Soldiers outside. Outside of their Hive where everything was the same.

He would talk to Revalantor Klbkch about the issue that very night. As Pawn walked, he clicked his mandibles together, savoring the flavor of his meal. Eggs and bacon. He'd had it last time, hadn't he? Well, Pawn didn't mind, although perhaps next time he would ask Lyonette if she had any good cheese she could add to the meal. He really liked scrambled eggs, but he liked omelettes filled with gooey cheese even more.

He was never coming back. That was what Lyonette told herself again and again as she wallowed in despair in her dark, empty inn. The fire was dying down again.

"Idiot! You stupid idiot!"

Lyonette buried her head in her arms and cried. The Worker—Pawn was gone. He'd left coin, but he hadn't said he'd return. Of course not! Who'd say that?

But would he come back in two more days? Or never? He hadn't talked much—

Because she hadn't been a good host! Lyonette remembered Erin being so friendly to the Antinium, but words had failed her when she'd tried to talk to him.

And he'd left so quickly. Had it been quick? It had felt like that to Lyonette, lonely as she was.

He hadn't liked the food. That was surely it.

Slowly, as the last flames flickered and died in the dark inn, Lyonette raised her head. She stared at the small, circular discs of metal on the table.

Money. The only money she'd seen all week. Enough for a few more days of food, of life. And she still had flour and salt and...provisions enough for a few more days. But that was all.

Water? The stream still ran, and though the water was bitingly cold, it could be heated. With enough wood. Lyonette glanced anxiously to the dying embers, the only thing warming the cold room.

She had lots of firewood, actually. Erin had used Toren to gather a lot of wood from the boom bark, safely denuded of their bark of course.

But she couldn't eat wood, and Lyonette was fairly certain that Pawn couldn't either. And yet—feeding him eggs and bacon was an expensive proposition, even with how much he was willing to pay! Especially if he only came by once every few days.

She needed more customers. Lyonette knew that. But who would want to come here, to this empty inn without Erin Solstice? To...her.

No one. No one but an Antinium. Lyonette clutched at her head.

More guests. Drakes didn't like Humans and Gnolls would probably try to kill her. But the Antinium—

They couldn't eat bread. Or pasta. That was the huge flaw in Lyonette's potential base of customers. How could she feed them with meat and eggs and other such expensive ingredients in the winter? A soup might work, but...any inn in the city could serve a better soup than she could, surely.

In her heart, Lyonette knew she was standing on a cliff. Starvation loomed over her head, dark, chittering. She had to do something. And she knew there was one thing she could do. She'd thought of it every night since Pawn had come the first time.

One desperate idea. That was all she had. She couldn't make what the Antinium truly loved—and she barely had the coin to buy enough food for herself now! But there was a source of free, delicious ingredients for them, wasn't there?

“The bees.”

Lyon whispered the word and shuddered uncontrollably. But it had been said. Now there was no going back.

Yes, there was one untapped source of food in this cold winter. One foodstuff that the Antinium would pay silver for.

The bees.

But they were a horror. Lyonette had seen them tear apart Toren when he angered them. She remembered the terrible, buzzing *cloud* of bees, some larger than her hand, enough to sting an entire village to death in minutes.

But she had no other choice. Lyonette sat in the dark inn, her heart pounding. She stared at the door. Every night she'd had the same thought, and every night she'd been too afraid. For two nights now. Ever since Pawn.

But he'd come back. He would come back. And she was out of options.

Lyonette sat in the darkness. She wavered. She found a wheelbarrow and filled it with firewood and kindling. She made a torch and wavered by the door. She rushed to the outhouse to pee, and then throw up. Then she pushed the wheelbarrow out into the cold and dark, four huge jars balanced atop the wood, and Erin's sharpest knife hung at her belt.

"Watch Captain Zevara, may I have a moment of your time?"

If it had been anyone else, Watch Captain Zevara would have told them it was late and to bother her again the next day. If it had been Relc asking whether he could take the day off, she would have burnt his face-scales off.

But because it was Klbkch, Zevara just sighed and resigned herself to a late night.

"Come in, Klbkch. Is something the matter?"

Senior Guardsman Klbkch entered the room, nodding politely at Zevara. He was always polite, and efficient, something she admired about him even if he was an Ant.

"I regret taking up your time before you go off-duty. However, I am here to make an...unusual request. And I must inform you that I do not come here in my capacity as Senior Guardsman, but rather as Prognugator of my Hive."

That made Zevara instantly sit up in her straight-backed wooden chair.

"Go on. Is there trouble in the Hive? An...Aberration?"

"Nothing so pressing."

Gracefully, Klbkch took a seat in front of Zevara. She eyed him, and his new...form. It still unnerved her a bit that after nearly ten years, he could suddenly look so different. True, two arms and a slimmer body wasn't exactly *that* different, but it was just...odd. Another reminder of who he really was, and why she had to treat him and any such conversations with care.

"Well, I am always willing to discuss your Hive. Is there something you need?"

Klbkch nodded.

"Yes. I would like to request that forty Soldiers be allowed access to the surface and area around Liscor."

Zevara froze again. She kept none of her emotions on her face, though, and pretended to cough.

"That's an...unusual request."

"Indeed. I would not normally ask, but I believe the need is justified and according to our treaty, Soldiers may only leave the Hive in times of war, or —"

"At the request of the Watch Captain."

Zevara nodded. She sat back in her chair, eyeing Klbkch cautiously.

"I see. And may I ask why you want to take your Soldiers out of the city? You've never requested something like this before, not in the six years I've served as Captain."

"Times have changed. I believe it may be useful to my Hive to present my Soldiers with an...expanded view of the area around Liscor."

That made no sense to Zevara, but few things the Antinium did made sense. She shrugged, trying to keep her tail still. She knew that Klbkch watched Drakes' tails and could interpret their movements almost as well as a Drake.

"I don't see any reason why I should refuse your request. Only— wouldn't taking so many Soldiers out of the Hive be dangerous? Of the six hundred Soldiers permitted to your Hive, wouldn't forty be quite a large number?"

"I believe we shall be able to compensate for their lack. In truth, our numbers are slightly below six hundred at the moment, but Liscor is a consummate ally, so I see no reason to worry."

Klbkch's face didn't change. Neither did Zevara's as she nodded at that barefaced lie.

“Well, reassuring as you find us, I’m afraid Liscor’s citizens might get a bit...nervous when they see Soldiers marching about. What would I tell them?”

“Perhaps that the Soldiers are patrolling to deal with any Goblin warbands in the area? I am cognizant that the citizens are restless due to the presence of the dungeon as well as rumors of the Goblin Lord. Seeing them patrolling might reassure the citizens of Liscor.”

That was a good answer, and even a helpful one for Zevara. She nodded reluctantly.

“Well, I see no reason to object—only, I’d hate for them to start a panic if they marched down the street. But then, I’m sure you can be discreet and find...alternate ways out of the city that won’t panic anyone.”

Through the secret tunnels the Antinium have dug. That was what she meant, but both she and Klbkch knew he would never admit anything.

“They will not be seen within Liscor if at all possible. Soldiers can be very discreet.”

Zevara nearly snorted fire out her nose. She searched for another question to ask—or something else to bother Klbkch with, but she really couldn’t think of anything. Forty Soldiers killing monsters *would* be helpful, and it was hardly likely that they’d start a panic. Ten years ago when the Hive was first established, maybe. But now...

“Well—fine. I, Watch Captain Zevara, grant you permission and request that twenty Soldiers aid in patrolling around the city. Twenty, for now. We’ll scale up the patrols if there’s not a panic.”

Klbkch inclined his head towards her.

“I am very grateful for your time, Watch Captain.”

“Yes, yes. Just make sure they don’t scare any travelers on the main road or run into any Human adventurers. Those idiots would probably pick a fight and that’s the last thing I want to explain to one of the Human cities.”

“I shall instruct them to remain far away from the northern road.”

“Good.”

“Well then, good night, Watch Captain.”

“Night, Klbkch.”

Zevara waited until Klbkch was gone, marching smartly down the stairs. Then she shook her head and reached for a desk drawer she seldom opened. She yanked the handle, cursed, found the small key she carried at

all times, and unlocked it. A blank piece of parchment lay on it. Zevara sighed, and began to write down every detail of her encounter with Klbkch. A report. She'd have to make copies, send them to every Walled City—which of course meant a trip down to the Mage's Guild at this time of night! Zevara groaned. She'd be getting to her bed past midnight, she knew.

As she began to write, Zevara muttered to herself.

"Take the Soldiers out? Why?"

But of course she never got any answers. Like all the reports she'd made on the Antinium's movements, she only had questions. Questions...

Like whether or not the Antinium were really their enemies. At least, the ones in Liscor. And if they were—

What could be done about them? Only the scratching of her quill on parchment was Zevara's reply.

Lyonette was not in her bed. In fact, she was as far from it as she'd gone in the last month. She trudged through the snow, fighting to push the wheelbarrow through the snow and ice. She *wished* she still had Erin's sled. But it was gone, with her.

Of course, the effort of pushing the wheelbarrow was only one of Lyonette's concerns. The numbing cold, the intense darkness, and not least, the pants-wetting fear in her heart were high priorities too.

What was she doing? Every two seconds as Lyon pushed the wheelbarrow she looked around fearfully, expecting a monster to leap out at her. But she had no choice. It had to be tonight. She had to steal the honey tonight, or she'd lose all her confidence.

And night *was* the best time to rob the hive, or so Lyonette felt. Bees slept at night, didn't they? Or at the very least, they'd be drowsy, and she needed every edge she could get.

It had been a long, uncertain journey across the plains. At first, Lyon hadn't even known if she was going the right way. Everything looked so strange at night, under the snow. But her treacherous memory somehow managed to guide her exactly in the right direction for once.

To raid a bee's nest. Even the thought made Lyonette feel weak with terror, but she had no choice. To survive, she had to do it. Steal bees right out of their nest.

Okay, maybe she couldn't steal live bees, but surely she could get a few of the grubs? Lyonette remembered the one Klbkch had eaten and nearly threw up again.

Honey. That was the real key. Honey was precious, and she could serve it to the Antinium. They liked honey, and with a few bees—

She just had to raid the hive. Full of huge bees that could kill her in an instant. Lyon couldn't get her mind off of the idea. Just one sting could—if they stung her in the eye would it reach her brain?

But—she had no choice. Lyonette took a painful breath of air. She was a [Princess]. She was a—

She was a girl. A [Barmaid]. Erin had left her inn to Lyon. Intentionally or not. And now it was up to Lyon to live or die. By herself. She no longer had any excuses. Either she died here, or she died in the cold and darkness.

Better here. Better with the flame of courage still in her chest. So Lyonette paused before the dark hole in the rock and took a deep breath. Sweat ran down her legs and back. She felt hot, even though the wind was blowing.

Bees. They were just bees, in the end.

And she—knew how to deal with bees.

It had just been a fancy. When she'd been young, her tutor had told her all kinds of things she'd willfully ignored. Lessons of algebra, governance, taxes, ruling, classes—all of this Lyonette had let pass her by without caring. But occasionally, in desperation her tutor would tell her stories to keep her interested. And Lyonette had remembered tiny bits.

One of those things she remembered was bees. When she'd heard how [Beekeepers] could harvest honey from the stinging creatures, she'd been incredulous. But a bit of smoke and thick clothing could do the trick better than magic could.

“Smoke.”

Lyonette stared at the firewood she'd hauled all this way. She carefully took the glass jars out and put them to one side of the cave's entrance. Four jars. This time she'd take as much as she could. If she could.

Fire. The wood was wet from the snow and it was cold, but Lyonette kept striking the flint with steel. Mechanically. She made a small fire at the entrance of the cave, working despite the numbness in her arms.

How many times would she have given up a few months ago? Before this, she'd never—she'd never even made a fire. She would have had a

servant make it, or at the very least used magic.

If she could have gone back in time, what would she have done differently? Everything. She'd never have come here, she wouldn't have stolen—

But if she never came here, she would never have leveled, would she? And she would have been stuck—

The sparks flew from the flint. They landed among the wood kindling and caught. Lyonette held her breath and then desperately tried to shelter the flame.

Fire. Once it grew, Lyonette fed it more wood. More and more, until the fire was hot and bright and large. Then she added the secret ingredient.

Flaxen sacks, grass plucked from beneath the snow—anything green that would smoke. The smell was horrible, but Lyon ignored it and kept adding her fuel.

Smoke, dark and noxious, billowed up from the fire. Lyonette stared at it, eyes stinging, but filled with wild elation. Fear had disappeared. Courage—she fanned the flames and the ones in her heart.

Soon, the cave was choked with dark smoke, and Lyon knew it would become overwhelming in a few more minutes. Perfect. She stared anxiously at the dark interior. She hadn't seen nor heard any bees, but they were further inside. First she had to build the fire. Then—

Thick clothing. Lyonette had many layers wrapped around her. It might stop one or two stingers, or slow them down. She had gloves, and the knife. It could cut into the hive, hopefully. She'd cut away as much honeycomb as she could and put it in the jars. If she was lucky, she'd even get some of the grubs the Antinium seemed to like so much. Then she'd run.

That was the plan. And it was a good plan, brave. It lasted in Lyonette's head, shining and full of promise, until Lyonette heard the buzzing.

At first, it was just a gentle noise on the verge of hearing. Then it became louder, and Lyonette realized the *thrumming* was getting closer. She looked up, screamed, and ran as first tens, then hundreds of bees streamed out of the cave towards the fire.

They'd come for the fire. That was all Lyonette could think as she sprinted out of the cave. By the fire's light she saw countless flickering shapes, and then heard the bees hit the fire.

They were extinguishing it! Embers and burning wood flew everywhere as the bees scattered the smoking campfire Lyonette had worked so hard to

build. They knew! They knew about smoke and they were unafraid of fire!

And then they came for her. Lyonette screamed as she ran into the deep snow outside the cave. She threw herself into the snow, digging herself as far down as she could, desperately trying to cover herself. All the while, she could hear the bees' wings beating. Like a maelstrom, like *thunder*.

Lyonette dug, wiggling herself down, down, crying. She heard a buzzing thing hit the snow next to her head like a falling stone and cried out. But the bee hadn't hit her! It had missed! Lyonette held as still as she could, tears running from her eyes. The bees couldn't see her. But they knew she was there and they began stabbing into the snow.

The girl hid in the snow, sobbing, while the thunder buzzed all around her and she heard *thumps* as the bees landed in the snow, searching for her. Hot liquid ran from her eyes, and more ran down her pants. All Lyon could think was that she'd be dead in the next second, then the next ten seconds. Then in a minute...

After a while, after a long while when the thunder had ceased and all the sounds were gone, Lyonette finally sat up. She looked around and saw the snow was torn and thrown about, and extinguished remains were all that remained of the fire she'd built. And of the bees?

Nothing at all. They'd gone back into their hive.

Lyonette stared around at the shattered remains of her dreams. She stumbled, felt wetness on her lower body. She looked down. The snow had dampened her clothes, but that didn't explain the stain around her crotch. She'd wet herself. She hadn't done that in—at least no one was around to see.

In the end, Lyonette stumbled back to the inn. She left the firewood behind, the wheelbarrow, the glass jars—she didn't have the heart to bring them back.

It was over. She'd had one chance, but it hadn't even been a chance at all. These bees didn't fear fire, and they were too smart to let the smoke fill their cave.

The girl stumbled back into the inn, still crying. She couldn't do it. She'd thought—but she was not Erin.

And even Erin couldn't have done that by herself. Lyonette clearly remembered the real key to stealing the bees' honey. The horrible monster with glowing purple eyes who'd tormented her so. But for all she'd hated him, he'd been instrumental. And he wasn't here.

The girl sank into a chair, wet, miserable, despairing. She buried her head in her hands, but now she was even out of tears. She was so tired. So tired—and so lonely.

She didn't have the skeleton. Toren. She didn't have Erin Solstice's twisted, insane mind either. Right at this very moment, Lyonette wished both were back and this inn was how it used to be. She would have scrubbed the floors all by herself, hauled as many buckets of water as Erin needed, even watered the flowers and—

The flowers.

Lyon's eyes widened with sudden memory. How could she have forgotten? She surged to her weary feet, ran to one of the windows.

She'd forgotten entirely. After all this time—Erin normally watered them. But could they be alive? Could she sell—

“No!”

She cried the word when she saw them. Flowers. Flowers yellow and bright as gold, a faerie's payment. But wizened, wilted.

Dying.

The pots of flowers Erin had so lovingly grown were full of—Lyonette stared down at them, her heart breaking. She knew they could be made into a drink, even if she didn't know how. The adventurer, Halrac, had paid in *gold* for it. If she had remembered, if she had cared about her duties from the start—

Now they were dead. Or close to it. Some still lived, and Lyonette immediately soaked the dry soil with water, but it would be long, too long before they recovered.

And of course, some were beyond help. Lyonette stared at one dead flower in despair. She picked it out and stared at it.

Another lost hope. Now her heart was well and truly broken. Lyonette stared at the fire in the inn. It was barely even embers now; the last flickers of light hidden at the center of the ash.

Fire had failed her. Angrily, Lyonette stalked over to the fireplace and tossed the dead flower into it. The faerie's flower smoked and gave off an acrid smoke. Lyonette coughed, angrily waving the fumes away—

And woke up on her back. Lyonette blinked, stared at the dead fire, and then at the remains of the flower. She blinked—stared at the way the darkness had become lighter, at the dead fire, long extinguished, and then at the wilted flowers. Then she sat up.

“*Flowers*. And bees.”

It was just before dawn when the girl lit the second fire just inside the cave of the Ashfire Bees. This time her body was nearly completely numb and she was shaking from exhaustion. She’d brought another huge glass jar, and a handful of the most dead flowers she could gather. She prayed that was enough.

The kindling refused to light. The wood was so wet from its exposure to the elements—Lyon kept trying. She struck sparks until her fingers cramped, and then the fire lit.

She fed the fire. She added wood, feeding it, growing it frantically. How soon before the bees noticed the flame and heat? How soon before—

She heard the *thrumming* again, but this time she was ready. Lyonette cast the flowers into the fire and saw smoke go up. But it was only a glimpse because she was running out of the cave, diving into the snow again.

The bees came, a howling sound louder than anything. Lyonette waited for them to scatter the fire, but suddenly the beating noise lessened. She heard small impacts, as if something was falling to the ground and then—
Silence.

Lyon got up slowly. She stared at the cave, and then dared to approach, holding her breath. The last vestiges of smoke faded and she saw the bees.

There were hundreds of them. They lay on the ground in droves, legs folded, some of them with wings still extended.

Asleep.

Lyonette’s heart beat faster. She grabbed a jar. She grabbed the knife. She danced about with both, and then wondered how long the effects of the faerie flower smoke would last. Then she ran into the cave.

Three jars of honey and honeycomb, cut from the hive. Two jars stuffed with bees, still alive but sleeping. Lyonette sat in the snow, far away from the cave, shaking so hard she couldn’t even stand.

She'd seen the bees waking up as she'd scooped them up into the big glass jars. But she'd done it. She'd cut into the hive, full of grubs and sleeping bees and taken as much as she could. Then she'd filled the jars, pushed them into the wheelbarrow, and fled.

And now—

Some of the bees were moving in the glass jars. There was no air inside, but they were still alive, somehow. Lyonette stared at a huge one that wiggled its feelers and moved its legs weakly. Lyonette smiled at it, lip trembling. She held the big jar up, gloating, mocking the bees.

"I *did* it! You stupid bees! I did—"

One of the bees inside the jar tried to fan its wings and escape. It smacked into the glass. Lyonette screamed, nearly dropped the jar, caught it at the last moment, and then put it carefully back on the wheelbarrow. She shuddered as the jars full of bees vibrated. She made sure the lids were secure, and then slowly made her way back to the inn.

She was *exhausted*. Lyonette felt as though her muscles would tear. Her bones...seemed to ache. And yet Lyonette held her head high. She smiled, even as she ascended the hill, pushing the wheelbarrow up to the door of the inn, legs ready to give out.

She felt so proud of herself, she could burst. Then Lyonette pushed the door to the inn open, and found a small bundle of white fur wrapped around a table leg. Mrsha blinked as Lyonette let light shine on her face, and then looked up hopefully. Her wagging tail slowed when she saw it was just Lyonette.

"Huh?"

The Human girl stared at the young Gnoll. The Gnoll stared back. Lyonette sat down, a jar of honey in her hands.

"What are you doing...? Why are you...?"

Mrsha just blinked at her. Lyonette blinked back. Then, tremulously, she smiled. Mrsha edged closer, wary.

"You're so *thin*."

That was all Lyonette said as she sat on the inn's floor, stroking Mrsha's head. The Gnoll nuzzled her. She was indeed thin, and she looked—

Sad. Lyonette couldn't read Gnoll's faces, but she saw it in the way the Gnoll curled up next to her. Sad, and lonely.

Just like her.

"Would you like some honey? It's fresh."

The Gnoll's tail wagged. And Lyonette opened the jar. And for the first time in a long, long while, as the sun rose and her weary body ached, Lyonette ate breakfast with someone else.

“Mrsha!”

Selys burst through the door of the inn twenty minutes later. Lyonette looked up as she and Mrsha stared at a wriggling grub half-submerged in a bowl of white, gelatinous stuff. The Drake stared at the Gnoll, stared at Lyonette, and then at the grub.

“What’s happening? Mrsha?”

The Gnoll immediately hopped off the table and fled into the kitchen. Selys ran towards her, and stopped as Lyonette got up.

“Is something wrong? Miss...Selys?”

“Um—no, nothing’s wrong...Lyon.”

The Drake glanced distractedly at Lyon, not looking particularly happy to see the girl so early in the morning. She pointed at the kitchen.

“When did Mrsha get here? I’ve been looking for her all day—ever since I found out she’d run away!”

“Ran away?”

The Drake nodded distractedly.

“She’s been doing it all week. I normally find her but this time—is she okay?”

“I think so. She’s so thin—”

“She won’t *eat*! Mrsha, come out of there! Come on! I’ll feed you anything you want, just—”

The Drake went into the kitchen. Lyonette heard scuffling, then Mrsha bounded out and ran up the stairs. Selys went after her. A few seconds later, Lyon heard another shout and Mrsha bounded down the stairs. Selys came down after her, gasping. She had to lean against a table as Mrsha circled the chair Lyonette had been sitting at.

“You can’t stay here! You...give me a second...you’ve got to come back, okay? Be a good girl until Erin and Ryoka come back!”

But Mrsha refused. Lyonette knew the young Gnoll couldn’t speak, but she saw it in every line of her body, and especially in the way the Gnoll clung to one of the tables as Selys tried to drag her outside.

“Come on! Please?”

Mrsha *yowled*, a noise more bestial than anything else. Selys pulled and pulled...but five minutes later she sat at one of the tables as Lyonette served her eggs and toast drizzled in honey. Mrsha licked her plate—she’d eaten so much Lyon was afraid she’d throw up.

“I just don’t get it. She doesn’t eat anything I give her! Not even steak! Do you know how expensive that is—and where did you get all this honey?”

“I stole it from the bees.”

“The *bees*? You?”

Lyon just nodded. She hadn’t even had time to change her clothes. She knew she was filthy and wet and from the way Mrsha had sniffed at her, she knew she stank as well. But there was something keeping her upright, and

“What’s with *that*?”

Selys turned a bit pale as she pointed at the grub swimming in the liquid. Mrsha sniffed at it and Selys pushed an inquisitive paw away.

“Don’t touch it, Mrsha. It could be...well, it’s gross.”

“It’s a grub. A bee larvae. And that—I think it’s jelly.”

“Jelly?”

“Royal jelly. It’s this thing in hives that bees make. You can eat it, I think.”

“Really? Well why not take the grub out and—boil it first, maybe?”

“The jelly? Or the grub? I’m trying to keep it alive.”

Selys paused, mid-bite, a piece of toast in her claws.

“Why? Are you—are you going to eat it? Do Humans...?”

“No. I want to feed it to the Antinium.”

“To the—and you stole honey from those killer bees Erin mentioned?”

“Not just honey.”

Proudly, Lyonette pointed to a corner of the room. Selys looked and nearly jumped out of her scales.

“*Gah!*”

The dead bees pressed up against the glass walls of the jars, obscenely squished together. Selys stared at them as she slowly pushed her plate away. Mrsha just sniffed at the jars, tail wagging with curiosity.

“Mrsha, don’t. Those are—come with me.”

But the Gnoll refused to move. And as she ran from Selys and the Drake futilely chased her about, Lyonette had an idea.

“She can stay with me.”

“What?”

Selys looked up at Lyon, panting. She shook her head, glancing around the empty inn and then at Lyonette.

“Out of the question. Erin trusted Mrsha with me—and she’s far too young. And besides...”

Lyonette knew what Selys was saying. Besides, how could Mrsha be entrusted to her, Lyon’s care? But she just pointed to Mrsha.

“She likes it here, though. She likes honey. And—there are lots of beds. I could take care of her. I could, Selys.”

The Drake stared at the Human and Mrsha chased her tail. But when Selys grabbed for her, Mrsha just ran behind Lyonette. The girl stared down at the Gnoll, and the Gnoll stared back up.

It wasn’t as if Mrsha knew Lyonette that well. They’d—well, Lyonette remembered feeding the Gnoll scraps from her plate and scratching her behind the ears, but that wasn’t what made Mrsha want to stay with her over Selys.

It was the inn. It was that Lyonette was here, waiting. And so was Mrsha. And no matter how much Selys argued and tried to coax the Gnoll to come with her—

“I’ve got to go to work. I’ve got to go but—this isn’t over, Mrsha! If I have to I’ll get Krshia!”

The young Gnoll hid behind a chair as Selys pointed at her. She quivered, but she still refused to budge.

“You don’t want to have her come up here, do you? Do you? Come on Mrsha—”

“I’ll take good care of her while you’re gone. I promise. I can make food—”

“Just don’t let her go outside, okay?”

Selys looked ready to tear the spines on her head off. She stalked over to the door, angry, upset. She yanked the door open and blinked at Pawn. The Antinium’s hand paused, ready to knock. But that wasn’t what made all the blood drain out of Selys’ scales. She stared up at the massive Soldier, huge, imposing, staring down at her. Her mouth opened, she gaped—

And then fell backwards in a faint. No one caught her. Lyonette stared at Pawn. He stared at Selys. Mrsha hid behind the jar of bees.

“Oops. I was going to knock.”

He nodded to Lyonette as she helped him drag Selys inside. The Soldiers walked in behind Pawn, so many of them! They filled the room, standing perfectly still behind their leader.

For a few seconds, in that moment when Selys had yanked open the door, Lyonette had wanted to scream. But that instinct had fled the moment she had seen Pawn. She looked at the Soldiers as they stood in the inn. They looked—

Scary. There was no other word for it. But all Antinium looked like monsters, didn't they? Until you got to know them.

Pawn sat at a table, clearly wavering over the unconscious Drake. He nodded several times to Lyon, and distractedly stared at Mrsha who was creeping closer to him.

“I do apologize. I didn't mean to scare anyone. I just—I had hoped you were open for business.”

Open for business. The words made Lyon's eyes open wide. She stared again at the Soldiers, but this time not as a stranger seeing something unfamiliar, but as a...a [Barmaid] sizing up a potential client.

And there was a lot of client, and a lot of them. How much could they eat? Lyon's eyes traveled to the jar of bees. Her heart beat faster. So she stood up.

And smiled. She smiled at the Antinium, even at the huge Soldiers. Mrsha stared up at one of the silent behemoths, and he stared back. He was missing a hand on one of his four arms. But he was a customer, a guest. And...oh, how would Erin say it?

Lyonette gestured to her empty chairs. She pointed at the bees and remembered there was a special pan for frying them. She looked at the twenty Soldiers, at Pawn, and at the Gnoll poking the unconscious Drake. She smiled, because she wasn't alone anymore. And she asked them one simple question.

“Would you like something to eat?”

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Sometimes it bothered him, the way others treated his kind. Pawn knew there was history behind the stares and frightened looks. And he understood that the Antinium looked...different, even from other species. But even so, it hurt a bit.

And Selys knew him! She was hardly a stranger to the Antinium. Was there really that much difference between Pawn and the Soldiers?

Standing in the inn, Pawn turned and looked *up* at the towering mass that was the Soldier standing nearest to him.

...Well, yes, actually. Despite Pawn's alien appearance, he was still just a Worker, with hands and recognizable body parts. The Soldiers on the other hand looked like they were made only to kill, because they were.

Their hands were formless digits that were more suited to gouging their enemies and smashing skulls into the ground. Their carapaces were reinforced, made to act like armor. And their mandibles were quite a bit bigger, so as to give them another means of attacking.

They were frightening. But the Human girl who smiled at Pawn and the small, white Gnoll didn't seem nearly as scared as Selys had been.

"I've got a ton of food for you! Just wait—I'll cook up some right now!"

Lyonette was practically running around, trying to show Pawn her latest acquisition as Selys sat taking deep breaths and Mrsha ran about, sniffing at Soldiers and darting away when they stared at her. It was confusion, and Pawn wasn't helping by trying to simultaneously apologize and explain.

"I am very sorry Miss Selys. I did not mean to cause alarm—"

Selys waved a claw at Pawn as she half-drunk, half-choked on her glass of water. She couldn't take her eyes off of the Soldiers.

"No—no I was—it wasn't your—why are there *Soldiers* above ground? Ancestors, don't tell me it's war!?"

The Drake looked horrified. Pawn hastened to reassure her.

"Nothing of the kind. The Hive has merely sent out a patrol to...patrol the landscape. We will eliminate any monsters we encounter and attempt to improve the morale of the citizenry by our vigilance."

"Improve? Our morale?"

Pawn nodded. That was the official line Klbkch had given him and Pawn thought it was a rather good one. Seeing Selys' fish-eyed stare made him wonder how believable the explanation was, though.

"I see. I see. I'm uh, well, I'm glad for you. This is a promotion, isn't it?"

"A promotion? Ah. Um. Yes, I believe it is."

Pawn had never thought of his new job in those terms. But the idea seemed to be reassuring to Selys, so he went along with the idea. She stared at the Soldiers, still standing motionless in the inn, all waiting for Pawn's next order.

"And they obey everything you do? Really?"

"That is their nature, sadly."

Pawn wished it weren't so. But the Soldiers really did seem to have little personality, or at least, the will to do what they wanted. Even less so than the Workers, to be honest.

A lot had happened since he'd visited the inn last night. After a rather... nerve-wracking conversation with Klbkch, Pawn had found his request to take Soldiers outside the Hive approved to his great surprise. He had also made a few attempts to inspire the Soldiers, to give them his perspective on life.

That hadn't gone so well.

The first thing Pawn had given them was a chessboard. Even when he'd explained how it worked, the Soldiers had just stared at the pieces. When he'd asked one to play against him, the Soldier had begun moving the pieces, following the rules, but seemingly without any idea of how the game actually worked. Pawn had played five games and the Soldier hadn't improved after the fifth game. In fact, he just moved the chess pieces forwards from left to right as Pawn slowly eliminated them from the board.

That was disheartening. But then Pawn had had the brilliant idea to give Soldiers names! Erin had done it for him. He'd sat with a Soldier—somewhat apprehensively as he knew what might occur—and given the Soldier a name.

Robert. But the newly named Soldier hadn't even seemed to react to having a name. Pawn had noticed that happened when he and Klbkch had tested the Workers and some Soldiers as well. The Workers either became Aberration or Individual when given a name, but the Soldiers didn't. They just acted like the name was, well...words.

It didn't seem to matter to the Soldier that he had a name. Pawn had hoped it would spark something in him, some sense of ownership, but the Soldier had just obediently responded to the title just like he would if Pawn pointed at him and said, 'you there'.

It was baffling to the Worker. How could the Soldiers not *care* about names? But then he'd realized—what use was a name if you couldn't speak it yourself? The Soldiers had no voices, no speech. They couldn't speak, and so what was a name for them? Just another word they would never say.

Pawn agonized. He'd given up in despair, realizing that he had made one smart decision. Within the Hive there was nothing to show the Soldiers. But outside—

Selys seemed like she was ready to go. She kept glancing towards the door, but she hadn't moved, possibly because two Soldiers stood next to the entrance, as if they were guarding it.

Which they might actually be. Klbkch had told the Soldiers to protect Pawn, and Pawn had told them not to attack anyone. Which meant they only *looked* as if they were contemplating tearing Selys' tail off and feeding it to her.

"Well, I've got to be going. I'm already late and there's so many Humans to deal with in the Guild...shame I can't stay and chat, Pawn."

Selys stood up, tail twitching anxiously as she edged towards the door. She glanced at the ground and called out sharply.

"Mrsha, come on! Let's go."

The little Gnoll looked up in betrayed shock—Selys made a grab for her, but Mrsha dove under a table again. Lyonette paused and turned back to the Drake, looking anxious.

"You said she could stay!"

"I did. But now Pawn and his—friends have come, I'm sure it would be safer—"

Selys caught Pawn's eye and looked away guiltily. He felt sad inside, and a bit angry.

"We will not be staying long, Miss Shivertail. I only wished to show the Soldiers this inn before we continued patrolling."

"Oh. Well..."

"Mrsha will be fine here. And I can feed the Soldiers as well. I have more than just bacon and eggs."

"Like cheese?"

“What?”

Lyonette looked confused. She hurried into the kitchen and came out with something on a plate.

“I just made this! It’s not as good as what Erin can do but—I found more bees!”

Pawn had been about to decline Lyonette’s offer for a meal. He didn’t want to impose, and he didn’t want to alarm Selys by having the Soldiers eat here. But all that changed when he heard Lyonette’s words.

“Did you say...bees?”

He’d had...one bee before. One bee. And like the acid flies, it wasn’t something Pawn forgot easily. He stared avidly at the thing on the plate. Lyonette had indeed just fried up the thing that Selys recoiled from and made even the Soldiers look twice.

A bee, legs curled, neatly sliced down the abdomen to let the insides fry on the pan. It now lay, wings folded, staring up at Pawn, making his intestines gurgle. It was steaming, and juicy with grease and honey. Pawn’s stomach sat up and *begged* for him to bite into the exposed innards that smelled...

Oh, heavenly.

Part of Pawn immediately wanted to eat the bee at once. But he stopped his hand as he remembered.

“Ah. Regrettably...I would love to sample this bee. But it would not be fair to the others, I feel.”

He was full of regret. But to his surprise, Lyonette just smiled.

“I have lots more.”

“Lots?”

Pawn looked at her hopefully. The [Barmaid] nodded.

“Two huge jars, in fact. Enough for you and all the Soldiers. You should have this one first. You *are* their leader, aren’t you? And then when you all come back from your patrol, I’ll have enough for everyone.”

Pawn hesitated. A meal had been in his hazy plan for the day with the Soldiers, but bees? He had a bag of coin, but he didn’t know if it would be enough. But bees...perhaps Lyonette would open a tab? He looked at the other Soldiers and came to a swift decision influenced not at all by the delicious bee in front of him.

“I am afraid we number twenty one in all. Would that put too much of a strain upon your inn?”

He didn't want to overburden the Human girl. Lyonette did indeed seem shocked. She swayed on her feet a bit, and gulped slowly.

"Twenty? I can...yes, I can do that."

"Very well then. We shall patrol and be back...in two hours? Roughly that time. Is that enough?"

"Oh, yes, absolutely! And Mrsha can stay with me—"

The Gnoll was still evading Selys' every attempt to get near her. Frustrated, Selys threw up her hands.

"Fine, *fine*. I've got to go! I'm so late! Just keep an eye on her, okay Lyon?"

"I will. And I'll have everything ready for you in two hours, Pawn."

The Antinium nodded, and, after Selys had left, led his Soldiers back outside. There they joined the other Soldiers who'd been waiting like statues outside and nearly given Selys a heart attack.

"As you may have heard, we will be eating a lunch at this location later today."

Pawn addressed the Soldiers who stood to attention, listening to his every word. He'd already gotten over a lot of the awkwardness of commanding them. They were the twenty least-injured Soldiers assigned to him, and they had obeyed his every order flawlessly since leaving the city.

He wondered if they were getting anything out of this experience. Well, they'd only left the secret tunnel just outside of Liscor and walked here so far. And this was a good place to start.

Pawn gestured awkwardly to the inn. The Soldiers stared at a wooden wall and then back at him, expressionless.

"That was an inn. People go there to sleep and eat delicious food."

They stared at him. Pawn coughed, and nodded a few times. He stared around. What else could he show them? It was the middle of winter, and there wasn't a lot of...

He pointed at the ground. The Soldiers stared down at the snow, ankle-deep around their thick legs.

"This is...snow. There's grass underneath. Grass is green and can't be eaten, but it is worth looking at."

They stared at the snow. One Soldier lifted a foot experimentally and crushed some snow underfoot. Pawn considered this a victory. He coughed again.

“I ah, will find a place for us to patrol to. We can walk and I can tell you...stories, I suppose. Show you the landscape.”

If only there were *flowers* and animals! Pawn agonized, but he was determined to make this outing a success. Somehow. The Soldiers might not be too amazed just yet, but he'd show them. And if he failed, which was likely, there were always the bees. The delicious, crunchy...

Pawn licked honey off his fingers. Well, he *was* the leader after all, and Lyonette had already cooked it. Besides, the bee had been small. Barely a mouthful. A delicious...savory...

The Soldiers stared at Pawn. He was thinking, and so they waited for him to give the next order. This is how they thought. Pawn was their commander. He had eaten something that was not mush, something that smelled *good*. That...intrigued them. Would they eat it later?

All of the Soldiers stood at attention, but they were not fully *at* attention mentally. In fact, all of the Soldiers were highly distracted by the scenery around them.

What was this strange place they had come to? None of them had ever left the Hive, ever gone to that mysterious place known as Above. Even when some Soldiers had been called by Klbkch to fight above, they had not been chosen.

But today, they had gone Above. They had emerged into the bright, *bright* world and found unending wonders waiting for them. They had seen...snow? Is that what Pawn had called it? And a Gnoll? Was that the fuzzy creature that stared up at them with huge eyes? And the fleshy thing? A Lyon?

While Pawn was thinking, some of the Soldiers looked past him. Up. Into the sky. They had never seen the sky before. Their sky was dirt and stone. But this sky—

Vast. Limitless. And so full of color. Some of the Soldiers felt weak at the knees, and not because something had bit their kneecaps off. They looked up and saw the sky.

The sky was blue. Deep blue, and the air was so cold. The Soldiers felt as though they would die if they stayed out here too long, and that was a

fascinating thought. The Hive was never this cold. Chilly in some places, in deep tunnels, yes, but never freezing. And the sky.

It was so blue. It was a color they'd never seen, not once in their time in the Hive. Just the sight of it made each Soldier rejoice inside, and realize that there was something to rejoice. Just like when they'd heard the stories of a better place, when the Worker had come to them and offered them—

“Ah, we'll go this way. It's not so crowded.”

The Soldiers broke off from their dream-like thoughts and snapped fully back into the world. They had orders! Pawn pointed, down the hill towards a flat area of snow.

“We'll look at trees. Trees are like grass, but harder. It turns into wood, like what this inn is made of.”

As one, the Soldiers stared back at the inn. That was from trees? They'd seen wood, but it grew out of the ground? Really?

“This way! I have so much to show you.”

Excitedly, Pawn set off down the hill. As one, the Soldiers followed him, some flanking the Worker to provide a shield with their bodies. They were going to see trees! What were trees?

Pawn was doing this to show them something. That was what he had said, and the Soldiers felt he had already delivered far past their expectations. They had only imagined another tunnel in the Hive, perhaps one bigger than the rest or with some unique feature like an interesting curve or mineral deposit in the walls. But this?

Trees. The Soldiers marched through the snow, cold and melting. They were going to see something new. Something they couldn't even imagine. And they were grateful, of course. But the Soldiers could have happily stared at the sky and watched the clouds roll across that infinite void...

Forever.

This was Above. This was a place their fellow Soldiers had never seen, a place where other Soldiers had fought and died long ago, in older wars. The Soldiers drank in every detail, from the face of the Drake to the furry thing called a 'Mrsha' that stared at them and made them feel so odd.

They knew they would remember this day for the rest of their lives. And they were all the more determined. They would fight with all they had, against whatever grave foe lurked Above. It would be a fair price for this moment.

For, surely there was a foe in the snow. The Soldiers watched the ground warily, not trusting the pretty ground any more than they trusted Pawn's assurances that they wouldn't actually do any fighting today. Normally they fought in three dimensions, where attacks could come from the ground, overhead—monsters could come bursting out of the walls or even shatter your stone footing to drag you into dark pits. What strange new enemies would come in a place where there was no dirt ceiling above you?

Their answer came when something white and soft flew out of the sky and smacked Pawn in the head. He stumbled and yelped as the Soldiers turned as one.

Sneak attack! From where? At first they didn't see, but then they spotted it. Some creature—many creatures of snow and wood! They stood, lumpy humanoids throwing snow mixed with ice and bits of rock at the Antinium.

Pawn wiped away some snow from his head.

"Oh. Snow Golems. That scared me. You see, these are creatures of ice and magic. They're not dangerous unless you are a child, not unless they grow to be truly huge. I believe we can simply av—"

The Soldiers *charged* as one. They thundered across the snowy plains at the Snow Golems, eight of them, who all paused as they saw a black mass of behemoths running at them full tilt.

The icy brains of the Snow Golems weren't capable of much thought, but even such creatures could sense trouble. The Snow Golems turned and began to flee, some plodding along with clumsy legs, others rolling across the snow. They were too slow.

The first Soldier caught up to a classic Snow Golem, three orbs of ice placed on top of each other and twig-like arms. It even had a carrot for a nose. The Golem turned and slashed at the Antinium. Its wooden arms broke on the Antinium's carapace. Then a shovel-like fist smashed through its face and it was gone.

Another Soldier leapt into the air, thrown by two of his companions. He *smashed* into another Golem, crushing the huge head with a knee. The Golem fell and the Soldier began to dig into its collapsing body, snow flying everywhere.

Realizing escape was impossible, the other Golems turned and fought. Or rather, they turned and had about a second to regret throwing snow before the tide of Soldiers rolled over them.

Standing in a state of shock about twenty meters away, Pawn watched the carnage unfold as his Soldiers tore the relatively harmless Snow Golems to pieces. They ripped the wooden arms off of Golems, pierced their snowy bodies with their fists, kicked Golems to bits and then trampled the remains.

It took less than a minute before the ground was covered with the... relatively ungory remains of the Snow Golems. Honestly, it just looked like a messed up patch of snow. The Soldiers marched back towards Pawn and he stared at them. They were covered in melted snow, and one of the Soldiers had a carrot in his hand. He offered it to Pawn.

“Oh. Thank you.”

Pawn took it, and then stared at the carrot. Why had the Soldier grabbed it? Then he remembered. Standard practice for the Antinium was to collect the remains of whatever they killed and turn it into food, much as the Goblins did. This being the only remotely edible thing the Snow Golems left behind...

“You can eat this, you know.”

The Soldier stared at Pawn blankly. The Worker handed it to him.

“Go on. It’s a bit cold, but it’s edible.”

And probably, far tastier than it would be when mushed with a thousand other bits of food for the gruel the Soldiers normally ate. Encouragingly, the Worker mimed eating it. The Soldier held the carrot up, seemed to hesitate, and then crunched into the carrot.

All of the Soldiers and Pawn watched as the expressionless Soldier ate the carrot. It took three bites, and when it was done, the Soldier stood at attention.

Pawn sighed. Well, what had he expected? He shook his head.

“I suppose...good job, everyone. Those Snow Golems...won’t be throwing snow at anyone else. Let us move on.”

The Soldiers followed him as the Worker marched on. Pawn stared at the bit of trampled ground as he passed and shook his head.

“Poor Snow Golems.”

For all they’d hit him with a snowball—filled with pebbles no less—he felt they hadn’t exactly deserved *that*.

A carrot! What had it tasted like? Was it really edible, just like that? The other Soldiers were agog, but they couldn't interview their companion as they marched. And even if they could—they didn't talk or use sign language.

Rather, Soldiers could vaguely sense what the others were feeling or thinking. It was more of a skill used for coordination in battle, but what they sensed now was that the Soldier who ate the carrot felt extremely... good.

Good, yes. It was a crunchy food, and it didn't *mush* and taste...like what they normally ate tasted like. And it was cold!

The Soldiers marched on, listening to Pawn's explanations of how Snow Golems came to life. It made little sense to them, mainly because none of them wore or needed clothing, but they enjoyed listening nonetheless.

Then they found the Shield Spiders.

It was a collapsed pit, one of the many lairs the Shield Spiders made to lure in prey. But the snowfall had been heavy, and the fake ground had collapsed, spilling inwards to reveal the nest. Already Shield Spiders were laboring to remove snow and repair their trap, but the Antinium had come before they could finish their work.

Pawn stared down into the hole as the Soldiers tensed as one. Shield Spiders! They knew this enemy. They looked at Pawn for his orders, since they were not under direct attack. The Worker hesitated.

"Oh dear. This is a menace. And Klbkch did tell us to remove minor threats...ah, I believe we should attack?"

The Soldiers hesitated. That sounded like an order, but it wasn't phrased like one. And the Shield Spiders had noticed the Antinium. Several large ones in the pit turned to face the Soldiers and began to crawl up the dirt sides, fangs bared for the attack.

"Ah. They have noticed us. I suppose we must do this then."

Pawn sighed. He sounded almost regretful. The Soldiers were vibrating with nerves and readiness for battle.

"Be careful. Do not take risks. And um—very well, now is probably the time. Attack?"

The Soldiers *exploded* into motion, charging forwards around Pawn at the surprised spiders. They leapt into the pit, smashing down on the many

Shield Spiders, big and small.

One Soldier landed and crushed a Shield Spider with his feet. Then he turned and grabbed another one. It bit at his arm, tearing into his thick carapace, but he ignored the spider's fangs. The Soldier smashed the spider repeatedly into the ground. The Shield Spider had an exoskeleton like armor, but after the ninth crushing blow the bulbous abdomen split and goo poured forth.

The Soldier let the Shield Spider drop and turned. By this point, the other Shield Spiders were long dead, trampled, kicked, and punched into shapeless forms by the Antinium Soldiers. Not even the smallest baby or egg was left alive. When Pawn peered into the pit he only had a few words to say.

"Oh my. That is quite...efficient."

Then he saw the wounded Soldier.

"You're hurt! Come here, quickly—I'll try to stop the bleeding with... something!"

The injured Soldier moved back, scrambling out of the pit despite his lacerated arm. The other Soldiers merely braced themselves, prepared for a second attack. They waited. They waited for the ground to erupt, for a hundred more Shield Spiders to come digging themselves out of the soil. They waited for an ambush—perhaps from the side, or other spider variants to come at them in a horde as so often happened in the tunnels of their Hive. They waited and waited, until they realized there was nothing to wait for.

Slowly, confused, the Soldiers lowered their arms. Pawn was busy fussing over the Soldier's arm, pressing at the seeping green liquid, not bothering to look around for other threats. Surely he wouldn't do that if there were no more threats? The Soldiers stared at him, and then around in confusion.

Was that it? Was that...it?

It was far too easy. Shield Spiders normally came in nests of at least fifty, or as many as three hundred! And where were the other breeds? These spiders had been tiny, barely hatchlings! Was this really all there was to fight?

Eventually, the Soldiers scrambled out of the pit and formed a protective circle around Pawn as he fussed over the wounded Soldier's arm. He seemed so concerned over the Soldier's injury, inspecting the broken chitin and green ichor seeping out of the wound. The Soldier in question

didn't react to the damage and the other Soldiers knew he was fully capable of fighting on. The cuts weren't that deep, and as for the wound itself, what of it? It was just pain.

In the end, the bleeding did stop, and the Soldiers expected Pawn to lead them on. But he didn't.

"I think we should go back. None of you were meant to be injured. At the very least, you should rest."

What? Did he really think that would slow the Soldier down? But yes, Pawn led the incredulous Soldiers back towards the inn. There he talked with the Human named Lyon or perhaps Lyonette and after a while, had the Soldier rest in the inn, sitting by the fire with a bandaged arm.

That done, Pawn led the Soldiers on again. They marched through the snow, staring at trees, crowding around to see the flower he unearthed. And they were ready for fighting and did fight now and then. But it wasn't like the Hive. It wasn't like the brutal, deadly warfare underground. None of them had died, which would never have happened if they'd been stationed on the front lines in the Hive. And they hadn't even been hurt—well, not *actually* hurt.

This was so easy. This was so...enjoyable. The sky was blue, and the snow blew at them, melting and wonderful. They looked and saw color and listened to stories.

And they began to feel something else. A word they had no name for. All they knew was that it was mysterious.

And good.

The Soldier sat in the inn, watching Lyon work. She was a Human, an enemy at times but not now. She was rushing about, gingerly taking bees out of the large jar and bringing them into the kitchen where the wonderful smells were coming from. The Soldier longed to know what was inside, but he was trained far too well to actually stand up.

He'd been told to sit and rest here. In this chair. By the warm fire which was also so fascinating. Pawn had said that, and the Soldier would not move. No matter how distracting the small Gnoll was.

She had white fur. White fur. Fur. All of these things were new to the Soldier, and he couldn't help but watch the way her nose wriggled as she

sniffed at him. She was curious, as curious of him as he was of her. She'd dart forwards, snuffle at him, and then flee when he looked at her. When he wasn't looking she'd sneak up again, and then flee when his head turned.

The Soldier was very conflicted about this. Pawn hadn't said *not* to look at her, but was the Soldier making a mistake by interacting with the Gnoll? Perhaps he should just stare at the fire. It was amazing too. It flickered, full of bright colors and ever moving flames. He'd never seen anything like it. The sight hypnotized the Soldier, made him long to touch the flames despite the heat. He'd never dreamed such a thing could be possible. He knew fire of course, but this—this was gentle, magical. Hypnotizing—

Something *poked* the Soldier in the side. He whirled, fists clenched, and Mrsha bolted, her fur standing on end. It was just the Gnoll.

“*Mrsha!*”

The Lyon-Human came by, scolding the Gnoll who fled from her as well. The Soldier watched as she chased Mrsha about, the smaller Gnoll nimbly dashing beneath tables and chairs to get away.

“Don't do that, understand? Don't bother our guests!”

Mrsha made a whimpering sound that did something to the Soldier's chest. Lyonette sighed.

“I need to find something for you to play with, don't I? Um...”

She wandered away, but stopped by the Soldier. She gave him a wide smile that looked...nervous? Was that the word?

“I'm so sorry about that.”

The Soldier stared at Lyon blankly until she backed away. Was she apologizing? To him? Why?

The Soldier had heard of apologies. They'd been explained to him and the others by Pawn, along with countless other ideas when he'd told them stories of God and other things. But he'd never dreamed of hearing an apology while he lived. And to *him*, no less.

The Soldier was very glad the Shield Spider had bit his arm.

As Lyonette searched for things to amuse the small Mrsha-Gnoll, the white creature scooted across the floor on its butt, tail wagging as it stared up at the Soldier. He stared at her. She stared back. She had big, round eyes that were brown with gold strata mixed among the depths. There was something in her eyes, the Soldier felt. Something beyond mere flesh.

The Gnoll and Soldier stared at each other in silence, the Gnoll occasionally blinking. The Soldier stared into her eyes. Something.

Something was in there. Something else. Something he'd never seen before.

Eventually the Gnoll got bored and scooted away to see what Lyon was doing. The Soldier went back to watching the fire. He felt enlightened.

Protect, Pawn had told him. Protect. The Soldier understood protecting, or at least, he'd thought he did.

He fought to protect the Hive. And his Queen. And Revalantor Klbkch and the Prognugator, if there was one. But he also knew that Liscor was part of the things he was ordered to protect, even if it was at the bottom of the list and a secondary objective in most cases.

But protecting the city meant protecting the people. And the Mrsha-Gnoll was part of people. So he would protect her. The Soldier thought about her eyes and the way her tail thumped on the floorboards and knew that this order was right. And he wanted to obey this order.

It was good. It was all good. And then the Lyon-Human came into the common room with buckets. She stared at them, scratching her head.

"I think...is this something Erin bought?"

She sounded uncertain. The Mrsha-Gnoll stared at the cans and poked one with a claw. Lyon-Human found something to lever open a lid, and then the Soldier in his chair saw what was in the cans.

Color.

The Rock Crab was a giant of the plains. An apex-predator, despite the fact that Goblins occasionally made snacks of its kind. But it was nevertheless one of the more dangerous monsters around—at least, during off-seasons like Winter.

For who could match the fearsome Rock Crab, hiding until the moment it exploded from the snow with huge claws that could tear apart almost anything? Corusdeer were easy victims of Rock Crabs, as were sheep and goats and other animals.

True, the Rock Crab had learned to avoid disturbing the larger nests of Shield Spiders, and during the spring it usually hid from the predators that liked to eat it as a snack. And the crab would certainly have been easy prey for any Crelers if they came to this area. But sheep? Sheep were dead the instant the crab saw them.

Now the crab saw something strange as it hid, a snow-covered boulder conspicuously sitting in the middle of the snowy plains. It saw the Antinium, black, huge bodies, many of them, marching across the ground.

The Rock Crab considered this prey. It didn't look too...appetizing, but looks could be deceiving. And the crab was hungry—it hadn't found anything worth eating in a while. So it slowly raised off the ground and scuttled closer to the Antinium.

They spotted the crab almost instantly. But that was fine—the crab could run. It increased its speed, and then noticed something odd.

The bug-giants were getting closer. Rather quickly. In fact, they were running at the Rock Crab like a huge wall. Black bodies streamed towards the Rock Crab, and it was reminded of the horrible green Goblins, except that these Soldiers were a lot bigger.

A lot bigger.

The Rock Crab reversed direction. It turned and ran as the Soldiers charged.

The Corusdeer herd was mighty. Rock Crabs were no threat when there were so many deer together. They could incinerate even the most dangerous enemy in seconds. But when they saw the wall of charging black bodies they ran. They outnumbered the strange things, true, but the Antinium smelled of blood and murder. And they looked like a wall, a wall of chitin and muscle and death.

The Corusdeer didn't fight walls. They ran too.

The Shield Spiders rejoiced when their pit trap collapsed inwards, drawing in food for the winter. Their rejoicing turned into dismay when they saw the huge black shapes of the Antinium and saw more leaping into the pit. But there was nowhere to run.

The dino-birds flew up in a huge flurry of wings when the Soldiers got too near the nest. Pawn wasn't surprised by this point; the Antinium were hardly stealthy, and all the other monsters and animals he'd encountered on his eventful patrol with the Soldiers ran the instant the Soldiers attacked. They could tell when bad news ran at them with several hundred pounds of killing force.

"Those are dino-birds, I believe. Erin calls them that although I suspect they have a different name."

The Soldier stared up silently at the fleeing birds, and then down into the nest. Pawn saw the eggs at the same time the Soldiers did. He marveled at the size of the eggs, and their speckled patterns, nearly invisible in the nest made in the snow. The Soldier nearest them raised a foot to smash the egg to pieces.

"Don't kill it!"

Pawn intervened as the Soldier prepared to destroy the nest. One of the Antinium's other doctrines was to completely obliterate any species they found underground, an essential tactic when it came to dealing with dangers like Crellers.

But these eggs—Pawn tried to explain to the confused Soldier.

"They're just eggs. I mean, the birds are...they're sometimes a threat I suppose, but they're not too dangerous and if they all died, wouldn't that be bad?"

The other Soldiers just stared at him. Pawn sighed.

"They're innocent. Don't smash the eggs."

The Soldiers stared at the eggs, but obediently left them unsmashed. Pawn led them away, and as they began marching away, they saw the dino-birds returning to the nest, calling out anxiously. The Soldiers watched the birds for a second before returning their gazes to scanning the landscape for threats.

Pawn trudged ahead of them, tired, somewhat dispirited. It had been a long two-and-a-half hours. In that time, he'd somehow managed to have his Soldiers crush two Shield Spider nests and chase off both a Corusdeer herd and a Rock Crab. Which was all good of course, and part of their patrolling duties. It was just—

Was this really teaching the Soldiers anything? All it felt like Pawn was doing was having them fight different enemies.

But he brightened up when they got close to The Wandering Inn. The patrol might not have shown the Soldiers anything special, but this—

The instant he opened the door Lyonette ran towards him, wringing her hands.

“I am so *sorry*. Mrsha was playing with some paint—I don’t know how she found the paint cans—and then she got some on...”

Fearfully, Lyonette pointed. Pawn looked and saw—

Color. It was splashed into the dark brown carapace of the Soldier, paw prints in white. They covered his front, his back, even his head. They stood out against his dull monochrome body and made him—

“I tried to stop her! But Mrsha wouldn’t listen and she’s *very sorry*, aren’t you, Mrsha?”

Pawn glanced distractedly at the small Gnoll who had even whiter paws and was hiding behind a table. There were pawprints on the floor as well, he noticed. Quite a few of them.

“Will the paint wash off?”

“I don’t—I think it’s really hard. This is the same stuff Erin used for the sign and I’ve been scrubbing but you need oil and a lot of work and I didn’t want to bother the Soldier so—”

“I see.”

Pawn just stared at the Soldier marked by the paint, along with the other nineteen Soldiers standing in the inn. Lyonette was apologizing again, but Pawn took no notice of her.

The paw prints. They stood out. The Soldier was marked by them. No longer could he be—well, just a Soldier. Before he had only been noticeable because of his wounded arm, but that would have healed soon. Now...

Paint that couldn’t be erased. Something to mark him, something that needed no words to make itself apparent. Why, it was almost like a name. In fact, it was better than a name, especially for a Soldier...

Lyon backed away from Pawn, eyes wide. He realized he was quivering with emotion and tried to modulate his shaking tone.

“I am not...not angry. Actually, I am grateful. Do you have more paint?”

“Me? Um, yes. It’s Erin’s actually. She bought a lot of paint, and Mrsha got into it like I said. I can give you a washcloth and water if you need—”

“I would like to buy your paint. All of it.”

“All of it?”

Lyonette seemed stunned. Pawn reached for his belt pouch and pulled out a fistful of coins. He put it on the table and she gaped at him.

“I would also like to postpone lunch for a half an hour. And if Miss Mrsha would like to help...we are going to do some painting.”

The Human girl stared at Pawn. Then she stared at the silent, faceless, identical Soldiers, and at the one who stood out. The one who had an identity. Her eyes widened. Then she looked at Pawn and smiled. He was already smiling, in his own way.

“Can I help?”

Paint. It was such a simple thing. Color, given form, something that could be added to almost every surface. It was just paint.

Just paint. Something the Antinium had no use for. Except that, as it turned out, it was the one thing the Antinium, the Soldiers, needed above all else.

Color. Identity. What could you give someone without a voice? A name? What good was a name if they couldn't speak it?

But paint needed no words. All it needed was a brush, a paw, a hand. And it turned identical, faceless Soldiers into people.

They sat in the chairs around the table, eating the bees Lyonette had cooked for them. Two bees per Soldier, not nearly enough in truth for them to eat, but augmented by bowls of soup thick with butter and fat and insect parts and some actual meat. The Human girl and even the Gnoll had pronounced the soup practically undrinkable and indeed, only Mrsha had even tried it, but the Soldiers thought the soup was the greatest thing they had ever had in their lives.

Nearly as great as having an identity. Even as they ate, the Soldiers couldn't help glancing at each other around the room. They had an identity now, an identity they had created themselves.

From paint.

It was on their bodies. Dabs of paint, splashes, some Soldiers nearly covered in the stuff, others with only a dab or two. But it was enough.

A Soldier with a handprint in blue on his chest sat across from the Soldier with white pawprints all over his body. They were two separate

Soldiers who could not be mixed up with each other. They knew that. And they were happy.

Happy. Happy was a word they knew now, a word they had *experienced*. Happy was having paint on their bodies, making them people. Happy was seeing the small Gnoll scamper about, and nodding at the Human as she buzzed around the room, serving bees and filling glasses with water. Happiness was a warm fire, and a bee on their plates, gleaming with honey.

What food. What delicious food. The Soldiers had no words, no frame of reference to even understand what they were eating. They'd always eaten the same mush, the only difference and interesting change being how rotten the ingredients were, or whether some parts hadn't been stomped and churned into complete paste. That was what they knew. But the bee?

Each Soldier ate slowly, gently tearing pieces off of their bee, trying to make each crunch of their mandibles last a lifetime. They didn't speak. Of course they didn't speak. But they thought it, and knew the others thought it too as they sat in the warm inn while the Gnoll scurried around and Pawn talked with the Human.

This was surely Heaven.

And when they left the inn, the twenty Soldiers, covered in color, they wanted to go back. And Pawn promised them they would, later, but the other Soldiers had to have a turn first. And the Soldiers knew this was true. The others, their brothers, had to know of this. They returned to the Hive, marching with their backs straighter than they'd even thought possible, heads held high.

And when they came back into the Hive? They changed it as well. The Soldiers marched down the tunnel behind Pawn, walking down the empty tunnel and into the main thoroughfare of the Hive where all the traffic flowed. When the twenty Soldiers first emerged into the tunnel, something happened that hadn't occurred in all of the Hive's history.

The Workers, scuttling to their destinations, the Soldiers, marching to the next battle, all of them—when they saw the Soldiers, covered in color—stopped.

They all stopped. For one brief second, Workers and Soldiers both stopped. Their heads turned and they stared at the twenty Soldiers, painted in hues that did not exist in the Hive. Then the Workers turned and began to move in sync once more, and the Soldiers double-timed it to their next

battle. But all had seen, and all remembered. And when the Soldiers got back to the barracks...

Red shoulder guards, crimson like Human blood but unpainted everywhere else. That was one Soldier who sat surrounded by his fellows. Another Soldier had white antennae and slashes in the same color running down his body. One more sat with a circle drawn in every color of paint Lyon had found, a multicolored ring on his chest.

They were not Soldiers. Each one was a Soldier, but each one was different. Special.

Unique. And they always would be. Forever. And the Worker who commanded them, their savior, the one who had given them identity and a soul looked at the other Soldiers and felt his heart stir.

Later that day, Pawn found himself in line at Krshia's stall. The other customers—mainly Gnolls—gave him very odd looks, but his [Humble Presence] skill helped so none of them ran away or screamed.

Krshia blinked when she saw Pawn.

"I did not expect to see a Worker here, yes? But you are...Pawn. Is there anything I can do for you? The Antinium do not usually need to purchase things from the city, yes?"

"No. I mean, yes?"

Pawn wasn't sure what to say. The Gnoll standing in front of him didn't seem hostile, which made him feel good. But she did look—tired.

Tired, and poor, so much as that could be used to describe any person. But Pawn remembered her old stall, and her old array of goods. Krshia's new stall was smaller, and she was clearly selling less. It made his heart hurt, but it hurt less when he told her what he wanted.

"Paint. As much paint as you have, in every color. Except brown or black. I will buy all of it from you."

The Gnoll blinked.

"All? All is an odd word, Mister Pawn, yes? I have many friends for whom I may sell goods on their behalf. How much paint do you need in buckets?"

"All. Everything I can afford."

And Pawn put the bag full of gold coins on the table and Krshia's mouth fell open. She blinked at him. He stared back.

"And paintbrushes. I only need around twenty of those."

That night, Soldiers went to sleep in their barracks. They were Soldiers, but each one was different. Each one was unique. Painted.

In a Hive full of thousands of Antinium, Soldiers and Workers alike, these Soldiers stood out. They sat in their cubicles, for once too excited to sleep.

They were all painted. They all had identities. The paint was dry on their chitin and true, some had already begun to flake off around their joints. But that was the thing about paint. It could always be reapplied. But the meaning lasted forever.

And word had spread, in the Soldier's own silent way, about what the twenty who had gone above had seen and experienced. A new world, new people. And so as the Soldiers slept, or rather, didn't, they wondered.

Was this what it meant to be a Soldier? They thought they'd known what being a Soldier was. But for the first time, they realized there was more. More they didn't understand. More they *wanted* to understand. And so they began to think. They thought of themselves as people rather than tools. They thought of themselves as individuals with identities rather than a mass. They thought of themselves as [Soldiers] rather than Soldiers.

And they began to level.

That night, Lyon practically sang as she cleaned up the inn. The place was full of dirty dishes. She didn't care. She'd been slicing and frying bees up all day, and there were insect parts all over her kitchen. She didn't care. She was exhausted. She didn't care. The floorboards were covered with paint. She didn't—

Okay, she cared about that a bit. The paint Erin had bought was very, *very* difficult to get rid of no matter how hard Lyon scrubbed.

But she had done it. She'd earned money selling bees, and the inn had been crowded and full! Lyonette stared at the bag full of gleaming coins on

one table and sighed happily.

She'd done it, hadn't she? She'd really done it. And the best part about tonight, the best part was—

She wasn't alone.

Mrsha happily jumped about the room, leaping from table to table like some horrible furry frog. Lyonette didn't mind. She'd already cleared those tables of dishes, and truthfully, she felt much like Mrsha. Part of her wanted to leap about with the Gnoll, and maybe she would.

It was just how good Lyon felt. She felt younger again, freer. No—she felt more free and more happy than she'd ever felt back in the palace. She'd done something by herself, with her own hard work.

And she was no longer alone.

Mrsha would stay here tonight. It wasn't as if Lyon didn't have enough beds, and the small Gnoll didn't seem averse to sharing her bed. And Selys hadn't objected to the idea after she'd seen how well Lyonette had done.

Okay, fine, Selys had objected a lot, even though Lyon had showed her all the coin she'd made. The Drake had been dead set on bringing Mrsha back into the city. She'd tried to chase Mrsha down and drag her out of the inn for the better part of twenty minutes before she'd collapsed in exhaustion.

So Mrsha would stay. Lyonette had promised Selys that she would keep an eye on Mrsha again. And Lyon would. Mrsha was...

The Gnoll belonged here. Just like Lyon did, in a way. And both Gnoll and girl were happy. That was how Lyon ate a messy bunch of slightly burnt crepes slathered with honey next to Mrsha as the Gnoll lapped at a bowl of milk, and the two laughed as Lyon fed the fire and cleaned up.

It was a perfect night. Perfect, even though Lyon had to pick up bug wings and legs and toss them far into the snow. Her hands were grimy from cleaning and she was covered in sweat. But Lyonette was proud.

And Mrsha was jumping around a bit too much.

"Careful, Mrsha! Why don't you calm down?"

The Gnoll barely listened to Lyon. Okay, maybe she'd had a bit *too* much honey. Lyon could only let the Gnoll tire herself out as she kept washing dishes and cleaning up. This really was a lot of work, even if you had a Skill, which Lyonette didn't. How had Erin done it? She'd told Lyon that she used to take care of the inn before Toren had...been created. How?

Lyon just shook her head wearily as she went back into the common room for the last stack of dishes. She looked to see if Mrsha had finally stopped jumping, and then raised her voice in alarm.

“Mrsha!”

The Gnoll jumped guiltily as she pawed at a familiar chessboard sitting in a corner of the room. Lyonette ran over, good mood vanished by sudden panic.

“Mrsha! Don’t—oh no.”

The Gnoll leapt away as Lyon reached the chessboard. She looked down in dismay. The small Gnoll had scattered the ghostly pieces and tried to build a tower out of some of them. She fled as Lyonette anxiously reclaimed the board. In dismay, the girl stared down at the chess pieces.

“Oh no. Erin’s game!”

Of course Lyonette knew the chessboard was an extremely valuable magical artifact, if a relatively pointless one. And she knew Erin was an undisputed master of the game. And she knew...

That messing up Erin’s chessboard was a very bad idea. Not least because the [Innkeeper] would go ballistic, but because whomever was on the other side of the board would probably be upset too.

With that in mind, Lyonette frantically tried to rearrange the pieces. But she had no idea of how the game had even looked! So...she put the chess pieces back in their original places, ready for a new game.

She knew how to do that much, at least. Chess had just been spreading in her country when she’d run away, and she’d learned a lot from watching Erin play. Mrsha peeked up onto the table while Lyonette was resetting the board, insatiably curious and only slightly guilty.

“Stop that!”

Lyonette swatted away a curious paw as Mrsha reached for a knight. The Gnoll gave her a hurt look, and Lyon’s heart nearly broke.

“You little...okay, you can touch since it’s too late. But only touch! Don’t move the board, okay?”

Eagerly, Mrsha picked up the ghostly pieces and tried to gnaw on one. Lyon had to stop her again, but truth be told she couldn’t blame the Gnoll. The chess pieces were like frozen air, the purest expression of magic. And the game...

“See? This is how you play. Like this.”

Lyon showed Mrsha how the pieces moved. The Gnoll stared uncomprehendingly as Lyonette moved a pawn forwards and back, and the bishop diagonally. She sniffed at the board—

And jumped backwards off the table, hair on end as a piece on the other side of the board moved. Lyon yelped and nearly fell out of her chair. When she got back up, heart pounding, she saw a piece had moved.

Just a pawn. It had come out diagonally to counter the pawn she'd pushed forwards. The breath caught in Lyon's chest in horror.

The other person. The unseen player, the one who'd sent Erin the chess board. They'd seen her moving the pieces. And they thought she was Erin.

And they wanted to play.

What should she do? Lyon panicked for a good minute before the choice was taken out of her hands. Having lost her fright, Mrsha peeked her head over the board and stared curiously at the two pieces on the board. Reaching the conclusion that this was some sort of game without actually understanding the nature of the game, she pushed another pawn forwards to see what would happen.

"Mrsha!"

Instantly, another piece moved, a knight. Lyon stared at it despairingly. But it was too late now. The other player clearly wanted to play. And Erin wasn't here and Lyon was...curious. So she played.

Why? Because it might be ruder just to leave the other player hanging. And this way, they would surely realize that it *wasn't* Erin on the other end. Sure enough, after Lyon had lost both a knight and bishop in quick succession (which she was sure wasn't a good thing), she sensed the player on the other end pause.

Had they gotten angry and left? No. After a minute, the play resumed, but differently. The moves were no longer lightning-sharp and too hard for Lyonette to counter. Instead, the pieces marched across the board, giving her a challenge, but not one she couldn't figure out. Mrsha stared at the chess pieces, first fascinated, then bored. To make her behave, Lyon gave her some firewood and some of the leftover paint. The Gnoll happily colored the log with a paw while Lyon played first one game, then two. Three.

After the third game, which she won somehow, Lyon saw the pieces on the board quickly rearrange themselves. She waited—the white side was on the other end of the board—but no movement came.

The mysterious chess player was done for the night. And so Lyon stood up from the board, feeling a bit ashamed. Surely the player was disappointed she wasn't Erin. But...

She felt good. Was this what Erin liked about chess? It was so odd, having to think in such a way. But Lyonette liked it, strangely. It was different and new. How could she have lived here for so long without trying the game once? How could she have been so...small?

The girl's head lowered. So much done wrong. So many things that were her fault. But she couldn't wallow in misery long. She felt a wet nose on her leg and saw Mrsha had finished with her log.

"So colorful! And you have paint all over your fur. Oh no. We'd better clean you up."

The Gnoll wriggled and tried to get away, but Lyonette had her washing her fur with oil and lye soap in hot water soon enough. It took many trips to the stream in the cold of the night to get enough water, but Lyonette didn't care.

Mrsha was her responsibility. So was the inn. So she cleaned up what she could, got as much paint off of Mrsha and the floor, and went to bed, exhausted.

But smiling.

[Barmaid Level 8!]

[Skill – Basic Cleaning obtained!]

[Carer Class Obtained!]

[Carer Level 2!]

[Skill – Calming Touch obtained!]

[Tactician Class Obtained!]

[Tactician Level 1!]

[Skill – Lesser Intuition obtained!]

Across the world from where the [Princess] sat up in bed and shouted in surprise, making the small Gnoll sleeping next to her tumble away in fright,

Niers Astoragon, the Titan, sat in front of his very small chessboard, a dark expression on his face.

He wasn't smiling. Rather, he was staring hard at the pieces on the board.

"So. The mystery player is gone and someone else has found the board. Someone who knows chess but has barely played it, if at all."

He mused to himself as he sat, staring at the board. He wasn't in his command tent in the field now. No, rather he was sitting in the smallest room of the inn his company had hired for its officers on the way back to their personal lands.

It was the smallest room, true, and all of his students and lieutenants had objected. But to Niers, the smallest room in the inn was still a huge space. So he had told them to shut up and move his belongings inside. They obeyed. Even though he was small, the Titan in a bad mood was frightening to be around.

And Niers had been in a bad mood for over a week now. His students tiptoed around him and the soldiers under his command leapt to obey his orders or stayed far out of the way. Niers stood up and paced around the huge desk he'd put his belongings on.

There weren't many. Niers passed by his arms, the magical items he carried into every battle, the artifacts any commander of Baleros carried, and stared at two things. The chessboard he'd sent across the world, and a letter that still smelled of lavender, edged with gold.

Two things, both tempting his loyalty. Niers closed his eyes. Magnolia didn't interest him as much as the chessboard—although the woman still had a way of digging her words into his skin like barbs—but she was on the same continent as his missing opponent.

Maybe he could...?

"No."

That was what Niers said. He sat back at the chessboard, staring at it darkly. He could play this new opponent of course. Maybe he, she, or it would eventually give the board back or find its true owner. Maybe.

But for now Niers couldn't bear to play such games. He sat in front of the board, scowling darkly as the one candle he'd lit flickered in the dark room. He sat, staring at the chess pieces, the letter, and then at the window. He had a job. A duty. He was the second-in-command of one of the four Great Companies of Baleros. He couldn't leave.

He told himself that. But his eyes always strayed back to the chessboard.

Waiting.

On the same continent as Niers' mysterious chess opponent and the famous Lady Magnolia, two hooded figures walked through blowing snow, keeping their cloaks wrapped tightly around them to protect them from the chill.

In theory, it was two people. In fact, the two travelers were followed by a rather large bevy of people, horses, and supplies that in theory were there to make their journey as pleasant and as safe as possible.

In truth, it just annoyed the Drake General walking in front to no end. He grunted irritably as his companion kicked up a small cloud of snow into his face.

"Did you *need* to bring all your attendants with you, Ilvriss? We could have been there by now if we didn't have to wait for these stupid horses."

The Drake walking in front of him cast a dark glance backwards.

"Be silent, Shivertail. Not everyone has a Skill to let them run. And unlike you, I'm a Lord of the Wall. My position demands—"

"Yes, yes, shut up. You didn't have to come with me, you know."

Zel Shivertail sighed and marched forwards. Ilvriss matched his pace, and the two Drakes walked forwards in the snow, silent, both of them disliking each other's presence. Disliking, but tolerating the other out of respect as well. And after a moment, Ilvriss spoke.

"I did have to come."

"I know."

They walked on. After a few minutes, Ilvriss spoke.

"...Hard to see anything in this damn snow. We passed the Blood Fields a day ago. How much further now?"

"One more day, I think."

"And you're sure you can find this Human in Liscor?"

"No. But it's a place to start, and as I've said, I have business in the Human lands."

"Well, let's keep on moving then."

"Mm."

They walked on, silent, marching through the snow. And they were not the only ones headed towards Liscor.

They marched on a similar route, also north, but far from any road. It was out of necessity they did so; they did not want to be seen. Not for fear of being attacked, but rather of alerting those who would watch their every move.

Unfortunately, moving so far from the main road meant they were more likely to be attacked. The raiding force of Goblins had been a hundred strong. The last of them now gasped and died in the snow.

The group studied the dying Goblin dispassionately. He had worn tough metal armor, painted black, and even carried a slightly magical sword. None of it had done him or his friends any good.

“More delays.”

That was all one said. He fanned his wings. The Antinium spat and acid melted snow into steam.

Another nodded. She had no wings, and her carapace was royal blue. And she held a staff in her hands and her eyes glowed with magic. She whispered a spell, and the snowstorm around them stopped.

“We are close. Continue onwards.”

The band of Antinium turned and marched away from the scene of their latest encounter without a word. Antinium, not the faceless Soldiers or humble Workers, but warriors far different from those in Liscor. Warriors from four Hives, marching in the snow.

North. To Liscor.

A woman made of bone walked through the snow, tireless, her eyes burning in the darkness. She was undead, a construct of death, a being of unimaginable power.

A dark shadow flowed at her side, something that moved without revealing its true form. The two moved through the snow, swift, silent.

They had been moving thusly for three days. And they had covered a lot of ground, it was true. But after the moon began to rise overhead the

shadow seemed compelled to speak. She cleared her throat with a wet, *squelching* sound and spoke with a whisper that would have chilled the hearts of any living being that heard it.

But there were no living beings to hear, and the voice wasn't quite so menacing as uncertain.

"Venitra. Are we lost?"

The woman, the armored knight made of bone, Venitra ignored the question. She and her companion, Ijvani, were on a mission to find the girl, the Courier, the Runner. They had been sent by their great master, Az'kerash. Being lost was...not acceptable. It couldn't be happening.

Many people were travelling to Liscor. It was just that some of them didn't matter because they were roughly seventy miles off course and heading the wrong way.

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When Lyonette woke up in her bed and felt the winter daylight on her face, she smiled up at the ceiling, so widely she thought her lips would break.

She'd gained two classes. Two. And she'd leveled up!

Part of Lyon had been afraid that it was all a dream. But the voice in her head—it was undeniable.

She'd leveled. Lyonette hugged her pillow as she curled up. In doing so, she rolled over and nearly squashed the ball of fluff sleeping next to her.

"Oh no. Sorry, Mrsha!"

Lyonette heard a noise of protest from the still sleeping Mrsha. Tiny claws poked her as the young Gnoll reached out and stole the blanket back. Lyon smiled at the round, furry little creature and patted her on the head.

A mouth came up and *nipped* at Lyonette's hand, making her yelp. Mrsha cracked one brown eye open and stared at the girl balefully. The message was clear: petting was only for happy, awake Gnolls.

For a while, Lyon lay in her bed. But soon the needs of the day got her up. She stood, dressed, and soon found herself paying a visit to the cold outhouse. It was well-crafted of course, and relatively warmer than the outside. But only just. Lyon sat on the toilet, shivering, but still smiling.

She'd leveled. She had. It wasn't a dream. She now had both the [Carer] and [Tactician] class, from taking care of Mrsha and playing chess respectively.

Two new classes on top of her [Barmaid] class. As Lyon hurried back into the inn she marveled at the thought. How long had it been since she'd last leveled up in her 'chosen' class? Four years?

Yes. Four years.

Lyonette stood with the glass of water in her hand, watering the flowers as she stared out one frosted window at the snowy world. It was cold, lifeless, and beautiful. There was something terrifying about it as well, a sense that if you wandered out into that vast, unforgiving landscape you would die, in this place where civilization ended.

Of course, when Lyonette went to the window facing Liscor she saw a city full of people and beyond that, villages scattered across hilltops. It was

only the southern window that was so bleak. But she liked that window. It showed her a world she'd never dreamed of in the palace where she'd grown up.

That place had been...Lyonette sighed as she went outside, bundled up, and tromped through the snow towards the stream, two buckets in hand.

She'd hated it. She'd hated not leveling, and she'd hated how boring everything had seemed. So she'd run off. To become an adventurer, or perhaps find a class meant for her. She hadn't had any idea of what that meant—to the Lyon of now, the past her seemed so idiotic.

Staggering, Lyon walked back to the inn, the filled buckets of water straining her arms. It hurt, even walking this short distance with so much weight. But her arms were getting stronger. She was gaining muscle and more importantly—

She was leveling up in a class. A [Barmaid] class, true, something completely unbecoming her heritage. But a class nonetheless.

Part of Lyonette shivered with delight at how *wrong* it all was. She was a [Princess]! If her family knew how badly she was sullyng her position by taking such a class—her mother even hated letting the princes take [Knight] and [Commander] classes.

It was a waste of her potential. But it wasn't at the same time. Lyonette didn't care about her duties right now. She just wanted to live here, in this inn, and finally realize her dream. Level. She had the [Carer] class and even a [Tactician] class! She wanted to level both up. She wanted to—

The girl had to put down one of the buckets to push the door open. When she did, she saw a familiar white, furry Gnoll cub running around the room anxiously. Mrsha ran in circles, hair standing on end, clearly in great distress.

“Mrsha!”

When the Gnoll saw Lyonette she cannonballed into the girl's stomach, nearly making Lyon spill both buckets. She clung to Lyon, sniffing at her and hugging her tightly.

She'd thought Lyon was gone. Gone, just like Erin and Ryoka. That nearly made Lyon cry; she held Mrsha tightly.

“Don't worry. I'm here. I'm not going to leave. I just went to get water, see?”

When she showed Mrsha the buckets, the Gnoll eagerly helped Lyonette bring them into the kitchen, although Mrsha had to push the heavy bucket

across the wooden floor. Lyon let her do it; it was a cute sight and Mrsha wanted to help. And Lyonette understood wanting to help, wanting to be useful.

And in this inn, Lyonette *was* useful. No—it was more like she was essential if Erin wasn't here. Without her working hard, the fire wouldn't be fed, and there would be no water, no food. The flowers would die, and this little Gnoll would starve. That was what got Lyonette up even when it was biting cold and made her work and count coins. She was responsible for a life now, and that was precious to her.

Yes, she was needed here. Far more than she'd ever been back in her home, in her kingdom. Damn being a [Princess]. Lyonette thought that, and paused.

She only hated the class because she never leveled in it. But she knew... if only she could level. But she didn't know how. It was too hard back at home. Too hard, because everything was too easy, and she was useless.

But what had Erin said one time?

"You'd be like a temporary innkeeper. This would be my castle, and I would be like a [Princess]..."

Mrsha looked up at Lyon in confusion, tail wagging frantically. The girl had to smile at the Gnoll as she patted her head.

"Let's make breakfast, okay? I'm hungry and your stomach is rumbling. And while we do—would you like to hear a story, Mrsha?"

The Gnoll nodded as she followed Lyon into the kitchen. There she watched greedily as Lyon cut thick slices of bacon and laid them gently in a pan to *sizzle* and *pop*. The girl had bought the precious and expensive meat for guests, mainly the Antinium, but today was a special day, wasn't it?

Bacon sizzling, Lyonette found part of a loaf and sliced the slightly stale bread up. A bit of warming by the fire and some butter and more importantly, honey and it would be a treat. She still had three huge jars of honey, honeycomb, and even some royal jelly sitting in the inn after all.

Life was good. Lyon fried the bacon—she was getting better at making it crispy, not black—spilling a half-cooked slice on the floor. Not entirely by accident either—a certain Gnoll ramming into her legs had caused the mishap.

"Stop that, you!"

Lyonette scolded Mrsha as the Gnoll pounced on the greasy bacon slice. The young Gnoll looked up at her guiltily with her huge eyes and Lyon had

to forgive her.

“Sit there and let me finish. I’ll tell you that story now. Did you know that there are types of classes in this world?”

The Gnoll sat on her butt, tail wagging as she chewed on the bacon and stared up at Lyon. She stared curiously at Lyon as the girl spoke, her eyes on the pan.

“Oh yes. Everyone knows there are classes, but when I was a girl—my family has many secrets. Many old secrets about the world and classes and levels. My father insisted I learn each one, as part of my tutoring. And do you know? I learned that some classes are better than others.”

The Gnoll scooted forwards, eyes wide, ears perked up. Lyonette laughed as she put a slice of crispy bacon on a plate.

“Yes, not all classes are equal. Of course, each one is important, but some are *more* important, see? Like classes that influence people. There are [Tacticians] and [Strategists] and classes that only [Soldiers] can take like [Sergeant] and [Commander] of course...but the best of all such classes is probably [General] or [Admiral].”

Mrsha just blinked at Lyon. How much did she understand? Lyonette didn’t know her age, but she thought Mrsha was young by any standard. Still, she continued.

“A [General] can have influence over a whole army. Thousands, maybe even tens of thousands of people. Isn’t that amazing? She or he can even affect other armies with Skills that demoralize or frighten...but there are classes that can do the same outside of battle. [Lords] and [Ladies] have their own demesne, and [Farmers] control their plots of land. You see? Some classes have *range*.”

Mrsha nodded and sneezed. Perhaps the nod was because of the sneeze? Lyon took it as a good sign.

“So what my mother told me was that the best classes can touch entire kingdoms. Like royal classes. [King], [Queen], [Princess]...a family of rulers can all make their nation strong.”

If they had high levels. Lyonette swallowed a lump in her throat.

“So these classes are some of the best. Because they are so rare, and only a few can have them. [Lords] for example are strong and have good Skills. But a [King] will have greater skills. There is no stronger class, in that sense. Well...”

The girl had to pause.

“...I suppose [Emperor] or [Empress] *might* be better. Because there can be only one, you see? A [King] can rule with a [Queen] and even [Princes] and [Princesses] all adding their Skills together. But an [Emperor] can rule over many nations, so only their Skills would affect the entire empire.”

Mrsha began scratching at her side, a clear indication that Lyon was losing her. The girl scowled; but the bacon was nearly done.

“Fine. You don’t like that? Then how about this? This is the secret my parents taught me. Royal classes, rare classes, and special classes—the kind that appear when two classes merge—they’re all better than normal ones. A [Lord] has almost the same Skills as a [General]. He can fight and lead, but he can also empower his estate. A [Blademaster] will have far, far better Skills than any [Warrior]—even a normal [Knight]! And you can get special classes by doing secret things. In fact, a [Princess] can even give someone a unique class.”

The Gnoll stared up at Lyonette, and then flopped over on her back. Her stomach rumbled loudly, and Lyonette sighed. It wasn’t important to Mrsha. It was special to Lyonette, but only because she needed it to be. Why would a Gnoll child care what a [Princess] could do?

“*Fine*. Let’s eat!”

Bacon and honey-covered bread for breakfast was a sinfully delicious meal. Lyonette ate nearly as fast as Mrsha, although the smaller Gnoll had even less manners than she did. She greedily chewed down the fatty bacon, pausing only to lick her paws clean of grease and honey every now and then.

When breakfast was done, Lyonette found something for Mrsha to do. She’d realized the Gnoll needed a distraction, so she found some parchment and charcoal. The Gnoll sat on the ground, happily drawing while Lyon cleaned the tables and washed the dishes.

She wished she had some of her toys, the ones she’d had back in the palace. The Gnoll deserved some fun. Maybe she could buy something? She had a good amount of coin after Pawn had come by—a lot, in fact. When Olesm came, Lyonette could probably persuade him to go shopping, but would the Drake even know what a Gnoll liked? Perhaps...

Lyonette was scrubbing at a bit of solidified honey on the table when she saw movement. She looked up and realized it wasn’t Mrsha but something else. Cautiously Lyonette moved over and saw the thing *move*

again. She was tempted to grab a frying pan before she investigated, but then memory nudged her and she realized what it had to be.

A white, wriggling larvae, big and fat and sitting in a pool of royal jelly stared blindly up at Lyon while she stared down in disgusted fascination.

The grub! She'd completely forgotten about it! Lyon had intended to give it to Pawn, but it had slipped her mind. Now the grub moved slowly in the white goo surrounding it.

It was still alive, and even fatter than it had been yesterday if her eyes didn't deceive her. Lyon stared at it in horrified fascination. The grub was ugly as sin, and sightless to boot. Still, Lyonette had the crazy urge to poke at it like Mrsha had done.

Resisting that instinct, Lyon frowned as she considered the liquid in the bowl. It was lower than yesterday as well. Some had evaporated? Or—the larvae had eaten some. It was growing.

Well, that only meant Pawn would like it more when she gave it to him, right? Lyonette decided to make sure the grub survived. That meant adding more royal jelly—she'd heard that was best for bees to grow with.

There were several honeycombs in the jars that she'd cut from the hive. Lyonette could see pockets of the white, jelly-like substance, and tried to fish it out so she could refill the bowl with the larvae in it. To that end she had to reach into the jar full of honey with a clean hand, giggling and shuddering at the odd feeling of so much honey.

She decided to separate as much of the jelly from the honey as she could, in case she needed it later. So Lyonette found another jar and used a wooden spoon to transfer the jelly over. It was a messy and sticky maneuver, and it invariably attracted Mrsha. The Gnoll licked both the royal jelly and honey up as Lyonette tried to fend her off.

"Stop it, Mrsha! Mrsha! You've just had breakfast! You're going to get so *fat*."

Which wouldn't actually be a bad thing. The Gnoll was still thinner than she should be, which is why Lyonette let her lick her palms clean, giggling as the tiny rough tongue greedily lapped up the sticky honey.

The grub wriggled when Lyonette poured the royal jelly over it, but in the end it was nearly covered except for its head again. That done, she placed the bowl nearer to the fire. Not too near—but close enough that the grub wouldn't freeze during the night.

That was how Lyon spent the first hour of her morning. After that, the door opened and Selys came by. The Drake wasn't working today, and so she'd come—anxious and worried—to check on Mrsha. The Gnoll was happy to see her since the Drake wasn't trying to take her away, and she definitely enjoyed the toys Selys had brought.

"I bought these for her. They're very popular with Gnolls but Mrsha never wanted to play back at my apartment."

So said Selys as she sat at a table, enjoying some honey and bread and a glass of honeyed water in the warm inn. Lyonette buzzed around the kitchen, making more honey water—she had the idea it would be very popular with the Antinium—and storing it in another jar for later. The inn was full of life, and guests! Not just Mrsha, but Selys had come to visit!

And—surprisingly—Olesm as well. The Drake came by every few days, less and less often since Lyon made him go shopping for her each time, but he arrived not long after Selys, tail wagging with excitement.

"Is Erin—oh."

He always said that. But he didn't look as disappointed today. Instead, he happily joined Selys at a table, eating some of her honeyed bread, oblivious to her annoyed look while he waved a sheaf of parchment about, unable to contain his excitement.

"You won't *believe* what just happened. I was in the city and Hawk—you know, the *Courier*—came over with all these letters! One had just been sent, and when he got to Liscor to deliver them, the Runner's Guild told him there were tons of undelivered letters all addressed to me!"

"Why didn't the Runners deliver them?"

"Well—oh, thank you. Is...why is this water sweet?"

"It's honey."

Lyon explained as Olesm suspiciously tasted the water in the glass with a long tongue.

"Oh! It's good! You should sell this! Can I have more bread? Selys has run out. Anyways, you won't believe what happened! When I was sending all my letters out, I misspelled my name! So when I got the replies—they were all addressed to Oresm, not Olesm! I can't believe no one at the Guild picked up on that mistake!"

Lyonette laughed, but Selys gave Olesm an exasperated look.

"Oresm? By all the Ancestors, how did you manage to misspell your *own name* when you sent all those letters?"

He hunched over, tail twitching defensively.

“I was excited! And I had good reason—do you know what I sent? Chess games!”

“You mean like the one Erin got? So what?”

Selys remained unimpressed. Olesm rolled his eyes, speaking faster as he tried to explain and convey his enthusiasm to an unreceptive audience.

“I didn’t *just* send chess puzzles. Don’t you get it? I sent the chess puzzle Erin made—the really hard one—as well as actual games she played! I managed to use the notation system she taught me—with it you can go through her chess games step by step and see how it played out without needing to be there!”

“So what?”

“So *you can recreate chess games across the world!* And play them, too! I copied that game she played against all of the Antinium—and the games she played on the magical chessboard! They’re a goldmine for any [Tactician] or [Strategist], don’t you see? It’s been less than a month since I sent out the letters—open messages to major cities, just the nearest ones that I could afford—and I’ve gotten back so many replies!”

Excitedly, he showed the two young females the letters. Lyonette had to admit, the stationary collection did seem impressive. Selys didn’t understand the significance, but Lyonette could see the quality of the letters was high in some cases, and some had personal sigils or seals. In a political sense, Olesm had suddenly accrued quite a bit of attention.

“Okay, so some [Tacticians] are excited about chess. It’s a popular game. So what?”

“Would you stop *saying* that?”

“So. What?”

“So—people want me to send them more chess games! I’m talking with the head [Strategist] of one of the Walled Cities, see? He told me the chess puzzle I sent helped him *level!* And this—the letter that came by Courier actually sent back some money!”

Selys choked on her drink when Olesm showed her the gold coins.

“*What?* People are sending you money for your stupid chess games?”

“Of course! Don’t you understand? This can help high-level [Strategists] level further! And if we can play chess by mail—I’m already planning on sending more of Erin’s games and more of the chess puzzles she taught me. I just...have to solve some of them.”

Olesm coughed, a bit embarrassed. Lyonette and Selys just stared at him.

“But when I do send them out, I’m not going to just stay on this continent. I’ll pay to have them delivered as a bulk shipment to every major city in the world! In a few months...just think of the possibilities!”

It was all a bit over Selys’ head, and the female Drake argued with Olesm over the cost of what she called his ‘silly project’, but Lyonette just sat, staring at the pile of letters Olesm so lovingly clutched, heart pounding.

This *was* big news. If Olesm was right, he might well be able to form a network of his own between [Tacticians]. Lyonette had—grudgingly—been taught history and she knew that this was how organizations like the Adventurer’s Guild, Runner’s Guild, and so on had been created.

She smiled at Olesm. She was happy for him. The Drake smiled back, and then Lyonette told them her big news of the day.

“I’ve got two new classes. [Carer] and [Tactician].”

Gaining new classes in any society was usually cause for congratulations and celebration, depending on the class. It wasn’t as dramatic as when people celebrated hitting their tenth or twentieth level—or the huge parties when people managed to reach Level 30—but Olesm and Selys still made approving sounds.

Olesm was curious about Lyon’s [Tactician] class—he screamed when she told him about playing on the magical chessboard and told her to play *him* instead, but Selys was more curious about Lyon’s other class.

“[Carer]? Is that really a class?”

Lyonette nodded, stroking Mrsha’s head as the Gnoll played with a wicker ball, rolling it across the floor and leaping after it. It was one of the toys Selys had brought and Lyonette was glad that it was too big for Mrsha to swallow.

“It is in my ki—my country. On Terandria. People get it for taking care of children, or the elderly.”

It wasn’t exactly a common class, but Lyonette knew some of the older [Lords] and [Ladies] employed people with such classes to help take care of them, just as the [Governess] who had looked after her had been an advanced form of that class.

“Don’t Drakes and Gnolls have a class like that?”

Selys and Olesm shook their heads, looking bemused. Selys scratched at a patch of dry scales on her wrist as she spoke.

“If they’re that old, I suppose we’d entrust them to a relative’s care. But I’ve never heard of anyone getting a class from it. Probably because Drakes don’t see it as a job.”

“And Gnolls always have a role in their tribes, no matter how old they get.”

So, Lyonette’s class wasn’t that useful in Liscor, especially since she was banned from the city. But the girl still welcomed it since it would help her deal with Mrsha, and it seemed to reassure Selys that Lyonette could look after her.

After they’d exchanged gossip and Lyonette had learned that Erin was doing well and Ryoka had gone north for some reason, the three adults sat in the inn while Mrsha played. They were all adults, although Lyonette was younger than Selys and Olesm, and even the oldest among them—Selys—wasn’t more than a few years into her twenties.

The two Drakes argued and sat as Lyonette made more food, bustled around the inn, and chatted with them. That was all she did. Just talked. It was all Lyonette wanted. She talked and played chess with Olesm and wondered whether Pawn would come by today.

She hoped he would.

Pawn had no bacon to wake him up, nor any honey. Instead, he had a meeting with Klbkch as soon as he had eaten the horrible mush in the Soldier’s mess hall. Given the choice, Pawn would have gladly eaten a vat of the grey-green stuff rather than talk to Klbkch.

But surprisingly, today Klbkch had nothing to criticize Pawn for. Rather, the Revalantor went over yesterday’s patrol with Pawn, highlighting the encounters with monsters and giving Pawn...advice.

“Do not engage the Corusdeer herds if at all possible. They are formidable combatants if roused, and the Soldiers will suffer heavy losses if they fight. Likewise, the Rock Crabs should be engaged with caution if it becomes necessary.”

Pawn sat in a chair before Klbkch’s desk, nodding nervously as the other Antinium spoke with him. It was strange.

“Ah, Revalantor Klbkch.”

The other Antinium paused and looked at him. Pawn realized Klbkch's new form was slightly taller than the Worker's form, as well as being slimmer.

"Yes?"

"Does this mean that you expect me to patrol around Liscor at a later date? Or are these simply things I should keep in mind in general?"

"Ah."

Klbkch had very few papers on his desk, but he extracted one now and slid it across the desk to Pawn. The Worker stared down at it in confusion.

"I cannot read this, Revalantor Klbkch."

Pawn could only read a few words of the local Drake script—enough to get around by, but not to decipher the words on the parchment.

"Of course. My mistake. I will take steps to ensure you and the other Individuals learn both Drake and Gnoll writing. It is not difficult—Erin picked up the word system very quickly as it apparently closely resembles the Human one."

Klbkch took the parchment back and tapped it with one finger.

"This is a report to Watch Captain Zevara, detailing the monsters you encountered. I submitted it last night after your patrol returned."

"And did the Watch Captain deem our patrol worthwhile?"

"She did. Although her praise is not the important issue—while on patrol I overheard several citizens expressing relief that our Soldiers were fighting monsters. Apparently they were observed chasing the Corusdeer herd off."

Pawn hadn't noticed any observers. He worried that this was an error.

"Oh. Should we have avoided detection?"

Klbkch shook his head.

"No. And in this case, the [Shepherd] was on a distant hilltop. But forcing the Corusdeer herd to seek grazing areas further from Liscor is considered a public boon, especially to travelers on the northern road who fear angering a herd. Moreover, the Shield Spiders you have slain are considered a public nuisance, and so the Soldiers generated goodwill from that as well. It also helps that people are seeing the Soldiers in a non-hostile environment."

All of this made sense to Pawn in an oblique way. He had intended none of this of course, but so long as Klbkch seemed pleased by the results, Pawn could relax.

“In short, it appears that your patrol has generated goodwill among the citizenry already. That alone is worth continuing your activities. Take twenty Soldiers with you today and this time retrieve trophies from the monsters you slay. I will increase your stipend of funds as well.”

If Pawn had the ability to do so, his eyes would have widened. He bowed his head.

“Thank you, Revalantor Klbkch. I shall...I shall put the money to good use.”

“Do so. I will expect you to update me if the Soldiers show any positive effects from these patrols. If not...at least they will improve Antinium relations with the city, which is desirable. You may take a second patrol out at your discretion.”

That was all. Pawn stood up to go, but when he got to the door, Klbkch stopped him.

“Pawn.”

“Yes, Revalantor Klbkch?”

“...Why the paint?”

The Worker considered the question, trying to figure out how to explain it to the one Antinium in the Hive who didn't understand. Well, one of two if you counted the Queen.

“It is a way of naming the Soldiers without using words, Revalantor Klbkch.”

Klbkch sat up in his chair at once and signaled Pawn to sit back down.

“This is very intriguing. Can all Soldiers be ‘named’ and made Individual?”

“I would not attempt to do so with the Soldiers not under my command. They may become Aberration.”

“I see. But you believe the Soldiers under your command have all become Individual? Really?”

“I cannot say. They cannot speak after all. But I would guess that they are...closer to Individual than they were before by use of the paint.”

“I see.”

Klbkch considered this for a while. Pawn sat at attention until the Revalantor nodded.

“Continue. That is all. We will monitor the Soldiers and your attempts with them before expanding to a larger group. If you notice them leveling or using Skills—”

“I shall report it at once.”

“Good. You are dismissed.”

Pawn left Klbkch’s quarters, feeling elated and relieved at once, which naturally caused giddiness as well. For once he’d done something right! Not just right—something *right*.

He’d given the Soldiers identity. Pawn went to requisition the coin Klbkch had promised him. The Antinium had a room devoted specifically for funds. Pawn saw a few other Workers withdrawing exact amounts and recording the numbers on a piece of parchment—some had to pay for supplies or perform other exchanges with the citizens of Liscor.

Carefully, Pawn collected gold, silver, and bronze coins from the carefully organized stacks of coin. He stared at the gold coins, and then wondered idly what would happen if he took more. There were thousands, tens of thousands of gold coins in the Hive, the product of over ten years of hard work and little spending. And this was only one of the treasury rooms.

But who cared? The Antinium didn’t post guards on the room because there was no need for them to steal, and no [Thief] would ever make it this far into the hive. Then again, if other Antinium became Individual like Pawn, who knew?

That was a troubling thought. Pawn took no more gold than he was allotted. He carefully walked up towards the entrance of the Hive. It was still early yet; he didn’t want to patrol before he ran a few errands. After all, he could only take twenty Soldiers out of the Hive with him at a time. What about the rest, forced to wait and guard in the tunnels? That had to be boring, so Pawn decided to get them something to make the wait easier.

“You want what?”

Krshia blinked at Pawn. This time her stall was deserted, and Pawn saw that the other customers shopping this early were going to the more prosperous [Shopkeepers]. Again he felt bad, but reassured himself because of the size of the order he was placing.

“Cheese. I would like enough to feed roughly two hundred and forty individuals. Enough for a small meal, at least.”

The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] just stared at Pawn, jaw hanging open. Pawn wondered if he’d made a mistake. Was eating too much cheese a *faux paws*

in Gnollish society?

Yes, cheese was what Pawn wanted. It was tasty and edible and it would go down well with the Soldiers, he felt. That was the only thing he could think of. Meat was too expensive and it spoiled quickly, and besides, it was hard to acquire in the winter. But cheese? Cheese was more plentiful.

And it tasted good.

Pawn stared anxiously at Krshia as the Gnoll struggled with shock.

“If there is an issue in delivery, I can arrange for direct pickups with Workers. And if there is a shortage...”

“No, no.”

Krshia smiled at Pawn, baring her teeth in a wide grin.

“I am simply surprised, yes? Even when my shop was booming, such orders were rare things. I thank you, Worker Pawn, for giving me such business.”

“You are the shopkeeper that Erin trusts. So I trust you.”

That was all it was to Pawn. There could be nothing simpler, nothing easier to understand. But Krshia lowered her head to him as if it meant something truly important.

“Hrr. I am grateful for that. Truly.”

Her shop. Every time Pawn saw it, he remembered what it had been. This time he decided to ask about it, since Krshia didn't seem to have any customers waiting.

“How has your business been doing lately, Miss Krshia?”

She bared her teeth again, but this time not in a friendly way.

“You can see for yourself, can you not? Rebuilding what was lost is difficult, no? I will survive the winter, but it will be a year or more before I am able to open this shop with pride.”

That hurt too. It was an odd, uncomfortable feeling, hurting for people who were not Pawn himself. He hadn't known it could happen before he'd met Erin. But this too was part of being alive.

“Is it truly so bad?”

Krshia shrugged, looking tired.

“Truly? It is not the worst. I will not starve and the others, the other Gnolls and even some Drakes have supported me. But it is bad to feel what is lost and know you have fallen, no? Because of one moment. Because of a thief.”

That last word was bitter, and Pawn immediately thought of Lyonette, laughing and serving them all with respect and pride. It was different from the Lyon that Krshia knew.

“I met the Human Lyonette yesterday. In Erin’s absence she has taken over the inn.”

Pawn didn’t know why he was telling Krshia this, especially because the Gnoll stiffened at Lyon’s name. But he felt compelled to, as if sharing the good Lyonette had done would offset some of the bad.

“She has acquired more bees and honey. She served me and a number of Soldiers the food. It was very tasty.”

“Is that so? Good for her. I have not had honey myself for many, many moons, yes? It is a valuable thing even when it is not so very cold.”

Krshia’s voice was hard, and he could see she was upset. Pawn thought. He thought quickly about how he could make things better for her, if only in his small way. He thought about Lyon and regret and honey. Then he had an idea.

“I will obtain your cheeses for you, within a few hours, yes? But first we must talk about prices and which cheeses you would like—where are you going?”

Pawn took a few steps away from Krshia’s store. She looked alarmed, but he reassured her.

“I am not reconsidering our deal, but I have a pressing matter to attend to. I shall return within the hour. Please excuse me.”

He could feel the Gnoll’s eyes on his back as he hurried off. Pawn left the city and walked swiftly up a hill to an inn. There he opened the door and talked.

“Oh! Pawn! It’s so good to see you! Come in, would you like something to eat? Not staying?”

...

“Other Soldiers? Later today? Well of—of course! I’ve still got a lot of bees and here, try this honey water. I can get Olesm to buy more meat and make another soup.”

...

“Please, Olesm? Please? And I need butter and vegetables—I have a list here. Oh, and let me add...”

...

“Krshia? You’d like to...well of course. I—will you tell her that I—”

...

“...Thank you. But wait! Before you go, can I offer you this?”

...

“What do you *mean*, it looks fattening!?”

Less than an hour later—less than half an hour later, really, Pawn walked back down the street towards Krshia’s stall. She stared at him. She stared at him, but especially at the huge jar of honey he held, walking carefully so as not to drop it.

Other pedestrians stared at the Worker as well. The jar of golden liquid tended to attract stares, Pawn had noticed.

“I have brought you honey. It is yours to keep and use as you please.”

That was what Pawn said as he placed the jar on Krshia’s counter. The Gnoll just stared at him.

“How?”

“I talked with Lyonette. She agreed to give you this jar of honey.”

It was a simple thing. Most things in life were, but Pawn had observed that the way people reacted to simple things was—complex.

Such as now. At the mention of Lyonette’s name, Krshia began to look angry.

“Why did she give this honey to you? Because you paid? Or because it is meant to be an apology?”

“She certainly feels remorse. I believe her acceding to my request was done out of guilt and an interest in helping settle the debt between you two.”

Pawn replied calmly. He watched with interest as Krshia’s ears slowly flattened on her head.

“And what does she call this? Repayment? It is hardly worth my stall, no?”

Some people would have hesitated to tell an angry Gnoll anything. But Pawn only spoke the truth, so his tone was level as he immediately replied.

“I think it is something, rather than nothing. An apology—the beginning of one, at least.”

That made the Gnoll pause. Pawn waited, and then spoke carefully.

“Lyonette has one message she would like to pass on to you with the honey.”

“Yes?”

““I am very sorry.””

That was all. But it changed things. Simple things, simple words, always did. That was what Pawn had told Lyonette, and why the apology she had given him was this. And what happened was that Krshia stopped growing angrier. She was still angry, but she let Pawn open the jar.

“Would you like to try some? It is sweet, and I am told there may be grubs within the honeycomb.”

The Gnoll sniffed at the honey, and then dipped a finger into the thick liquid. It came out glistening, and Pawn stared at the honey in envy. He liked honey. Maybe he should have gotten some to go with the cheese. He’d go back to ask Lyonette about it later. But this jar was Krshia’s.

“Hmf.”

She licked the honey off of her finger. Slowly, Krshia’s tail began to wag, although her face didn’t change.

“This is good. Sweet. Sweeter than honey from small bees, yes?”

“Mm. I believe so.”

The Gnoll nodded. She stared at Pawn.

“You are an odd Worker, Pawn of the Antinium. But...yes, I believe you and Klbkch are good for this city.”

“Thank you.”

Pawn nodded to Krshia. He felt happy for her words because she clearly meant them. Krshia nodded and smiled. When he left, it was with all the cheese in the marketplace and locations for Workers to pick up more. And Krshia was selling honey in the form of hand-sized jars. There was already a queue.

Lyonette felt good after Pawn had left. She felt better when he came back with his Soldiers. She cooked and served food again, and that night when she was cleaning up, she couldn’t stop humming.

The jars she and Erin used were truly big. They were taller than her knees and very wide—Erin had paid in gold for them since they were made by expert [Glassblowers]. At the moment she had two jars of honey, one half-empty and one and a quarter jars of dead bees. Even with the Soldiers' appetite, Lyonette still had a lot left.

Well, she wouldn't if she was actually feeding the Soldiers a full meal. Then she would have had to give them six or seven bees to fill them up, but two or three for a lunchtime snack was all Pawn had asked for.

And the honey? The honey had brought in more than a few guests—all Drakes—who'd come to drink a few glasses of honeyed water and fill their jars with the sweet honey and honeycomb. It wasn't exactly filling tables at the inn, but it was more money.

And when Lyonette had sat down with Mrsha to eat a proper meal of shepherd's pie—courtesy of Selys who taught Lyonette how to make it—they had one more unexpected guest.

Klbkch.

He came into the inn while the two were eating. Lyonette wanted to find him a table, but the Antinium declined.

"I shall not be here long. Rather, I would like to make a purchase."

"Of the bees?"

Klbkch nodded. He pointed to one of the jars Lyonette kept against the kitchen wall.

"How much...for the entire jar?"

"The entire jar?"

Klbkch nodded, looking at Lyonette's ecstatic and panicked expression.

"I believe my Queen will enjoy the bees. Will you sell them to me directly?"

That was actually something of a hard question for Lyonette. Should she sell the bees? If she did, she might not have enough for Pawn tomorrow, and he was bringing more Soldiers then as well.

But a whole jar? All of Lyonette's instincts told her to say yes. After all she could always get more bees, even if she was afraid of taking too much honey from the Hive. She had more flowers—hopefully she could use less this time—and she had to do it sooner or later.

"Of course I'll sell you—the entire jar, you said?"

"Yes. Will that be an issue?"

“No, no! But the bees—they’re raw. Would you like me to fry them up first? They taste really good when they’re drizzled in honey. Apparently.”

“Hm. We have a [Cook], but perhaps it will be instructive to show him how it is done. By all means, please prepare a third of the jar. I will partake of a few as well to ascertain quality.”

In the end, Lyonette finished eating with Mrsha and then went into the kitchen to cook while the Gnoll played hide and seek with Klbkch. Although that really just involved Klbkch pointing at her while the Gnoll roamed around the inn, trying to be stealthy.

Cut, fry, drizzle. Lyonette worked tirelessly to make the best bees possible, conscious of who would be eating them. The Queen. And also, Klbkch, whom Pawn told Lyon was actually very important in the Hive. Klbkch ate five while he was waiting.

“Thank you. These bees are quite delicious. I may return at a later date if you have more stored away.”

“I will. Thank you for buying them! Have a good night!”

That was how Lyonette spent the rest of her day. She went to bed exhausted, but remembered to put the bee larvae very close to the dying fire as she did. Pawn didn’t want it, and she’d neglected to offer one to Klbkch. It kept slipping her mind. And besides—Lyonette stared at the larvae, wriggling blind in the bowl.

...She might be getting attached to it.

That night, she leveled up in all three of her new classes again, although she got no new Skills. That would have been enough, but Lyonette heard a new announcement after the list of level ups.

[Beast Tamer Class Obtained!]

[Beast Tamer Level 1!]

[Skill – Healthy Rearing obtained!]

[Beast Tamer]? Her?

Lyonette couldn’t believe it. But when she woke up, she knew it had happened again.

A new class! Why?

Because she'd taken care of the bee? Because she'd made sure it was warm and fed? Because she'd done all that? Was that all it took?

She couldn't be a [Beast Tamer]. Of all the classes, Lyonette felt least confident in that one. What purpose would it serve her? Was she going to raise a bee? As a pet? It was a useless class. Well, the [Tactician] class was also useless to her, strictly speaking.

And yet—Lyonette *wanted* the class. She wanted the [Tactician] class too. And the [Barmaid] class she'd leveled up in! She wanted to level! No matter what class, no matter how few levels!

She wanted them. And from what Lyonette knew of classes, that was probably why she'd gotten them. Because while other people had no desire to devote their lives to raising animals or monsters and so didn't get the class even if they owned pets, Lyonette was different.

She had been starved of classes, not leveled while growing up. And now that she was free, truly free—

She'd take all the classes. No matter how damning it might be to her one 'true' class. Even if it meant she'd never reach a high level. She never levelled in it anyways.

With that in mind, Lyonette added a new routine to her day. After she watered Erin's flowers and stoked the fire and before she went to fetch more water, she checked on the bee. It wriggled in the royal jelly and she saw it was a bit larger again. Lyonette wondered whether it would actually grow up—this was no hive. But she could always get more royal jelly and she did have a Skill to help her, after all.

"I guess you're going to need a name."

So saying, Lyonette touched the bee gently. It squirmed and it was wet and slimy. Gross, in short. But it was alive, and it struggled to stay alive.

Just like her.

One last thing happened that morning. When Lyonette was trudging back to her inn, she saw a Gnoll pulling a sled up the hill. She froze in fear, but the Gnoll's sled was loaded with goods.

Food. Lyonette saw meats, vegetables, and all the things she'd asked Olesm to bring, neatly bundled up on the sled. The Gnoll set it down in the snow outside the inn. She—the Gnoll was a she now that Lyonette was closer—turned and saw Lyon with the buckets in hand.

"Delivery."

That was all she said. She must have been one of the Street Runners the shops hired. But Olesm had told Lyon that no one would deliver to the inn, to her. What had changed?

The Gnoll began walking down the hill. With a start, Lyonette realized she was going.

“Oh. T-thank you so...”

The Gnoll [Runner] made no reply. She just growled something and stomped back down the hill, dragging the sled behind her.

Lyon watched her go. Then she opened the door and had Mrsha help her drag everything inside. She didn’t say much, but she was smiling. And crying.

“They are coming.”

That was all Klbkch said to Bird, Pawn, Belgrade, Garry, and Anand when he gathered them together for the first time in his small quarters. It was early morning, just after dawn, in fact. The Workers had been roused—in Pawn’s case from his sleep by the mental order—and told to come here.

Now Klbkch paced back and forth in front of them, clearly agitated. The other Workers said nothing, but they each felt slightly alarmed. None of them had ever seen the Revalantor like this.

“Pardon, Revalantor Klbkch, but who is coming?”

That came from Garry. Pawn hadn’t seen Garry in...so long! Klbkch had even ordered Garry to attend. That was unusual because Garry was specialized now in the [Cook] class—he played no part in commanding Soldiers and indeed, he stayed far away from any area of the Hive where monsters might attack.

“The other Hives. They have sent a delegation, and they will arrive sometime today.”

That was all Klbkch said, but it shocked all the other Workers to their core.

Another Hive? They knew—all the Workers and Soldiers knew in an oblique way that other Hives existed. But they had never seen or even heard of the other Hives until today. Liscor was far from their location, and the Antinium did not move between cities like other races.

“Why are they coming?”

“To see you. To greet my Queen and to see you. And appraise what value you have as Individuals.”

Klbgkch never gave them detailed explanations. Pawn knew that was because he and the other Workers weren’t that important, but he *wished* the Antinium would trust them with more. He remembered Klbgkch’s promise. If he made something out of the Soldiers, he would be told more.

“What should we do? What will the other Antinium ask of us?”

That came from Belgrade. He was probably the most worried, among the Workers, Pawn felt. Bird was usually calm, Garry was hard to ruffle, and Anand looked like he was actually enjoying this new development.

“Do not...worry.”

Klbgkch said it as if he had to remember they could be worried.

“All you have to do is demonstrate your Skills. Questions will be asked—answer them to the best of your ability. It will not be difficult.”

He paused, looking the Workers over. Klbgkch seemed to think, and then tapped the pommel of one of his swords slowly as he spoke.

“Some of the other Antinium may be...different. Unsettling. Odd, even. They are not Aberrations, rather they are created from a different template than we are. And the other Queens do not think as mine—ours does. Remember that.”

Pawn worried. What did that mean? Did they have Individuals of their own? But surely Klbgkch would have mentioned that. He went on, looking at each of the Workers in turn as he gave them orders.

“Belgrade, Anand, and Bird will showcase their talents. Bird’s archery skills have much merit, as do Belgrade and Anand. They have the most value as [Tacticians] and as leaders of Soldiers. Garry will prepare meals to demonstrate his talents. Pawn—”

He glanced at the Worker. Pawn stood straight, holding his breathe, apprehensive.

“You will answer any questions directed to you if the others realize you are Individual as well. Do *not* volunteer information about your [Acolyte] class unless I address it specifically. That goes for all of you. Make no mention of that class, and not of Pawn either unless it is clear the others know about you.”

It felt like someone—Ryoka perhaps—had kicked Pawn in the stomach. He stood still, wrestling with his emotions.

Of course. He wasn't that useful and his Skills still weren't quantifiable. And from what Klbkch had said, his class pertained to Gods and Gods—

It still hurt. Even as Klbkch dismissed them and the Workers walked away to speak in an empty corridor in privacy, Pawn felt it hurting in his chest.

He wanted to be noticed. He wanted to be useful. But here—Pawn forced himself to listen to the conversation. It was the first time in a while he and the other Workers could talk, so they were all asking Garry what he had been doing in his new job.

The Worker nodded, folding his four hands together. He seemed slightly bigger than Pawn last remembered him—was he gaining weight? He still wore a slightly stained apron around his front, a piece of apparel that intrigued the other Workers greatly.

"I have been preparing meals for the Queen. I take monster parts and other edible foodstuffs and create food for her rather than the...paste...we are usually fed."

The other Workers exchanged a glance, and then nodded their heads.

"Ah."

"I see."

"This intrigues me."

"Will you cook us such food?"

Garry nodded.

"If I am allowed. I believe Revalantor Klbkch wishes for me to cook for other members of the Hive, including himself. However, the Queen desires me to prepare food for her alone. I gather this is a source of contention between the two."

That was fascinating. But Garry didn't have details, so the other Workers quickly summarized what they had been doing. Belgrade and Anand had helped take down a Crypt Worm recently—Bird roamed the landscape, hunting animals with a bow and arrow. His life seemed exciting to Pawn, but the other Workers claimed he was actually the one with the most interest.

"I do not interact with any other species, Pawn. You are fortunate to talk with a Human on a daily basis."

Anand and Belgrade nodded as Bird said this. Pawn couldn't help staring at the feather hanging from a simple cord around Bird's neck. It was a very red feather, and beautiful, too.

“I am envious. I have not been allowed to go to the surface.”

“Indeed. My duties keep me below at all times.”

“Does this Lyonette serve cooked birds?”

Pawn saw the keen interest in the other Worker’s eyes. He realized with a pang that they had never experienced what he had, and resolved to petition Klbkch to let them join him on a patrol. In the meantime, he could certainly bring some of what was above down below. He only regretted that the Soldiers had eaten all the cheese. If only he had his own quarters so he could store objects in them!

“The bees Lyon makes are very tasty. I shall bring you some, next time I go.”

“I believe Klbkch bought some for the Queen. I sampled one—the others have already been eaten. I shall attempt to replicate such treats for the rest of you and our guests.”

Just the thought of Garry’s cooking filled Pawn with hunger. He clicked his mandibles together sadly though, reflecting on his role.

“I regret that I cannot bring any value to the Hive. And that you must lie about my abilities.”

To Pawn’s surprise, Garry shook his head. He placed one of his hands on Pawn’s shoulders.

“Do not worry. You have value. In fact, it is I who envy you. You may not be of apparent worth to these Antinium who come, but you are special, even among us. One day, I believe your talents will surpass us all.”

Belgrade, Anand, and Bird all nodded.

“Agreed.”

“Yes.”

“I will hunt birds to showcase my abilities.”

The other Workers looked at him. Bird shrugged.

“I like birds.”

They were coming. At last, after all this time...the other Hives were coming. They were taking notice. Klbkch had to sit down after the other Workers had left. He tried to contain his excitement, but his hands shook slightly.

They were coming. And not just any lowly Workers or Soldiers, no. Klbkch knew this group had to include Prognugators, valuable members of each Hive, sent to observe and be their Queen's eyes. They would observe him and he would see...see how much each Hive had changed since he had last travelled south.

All of that would have been dramatic enough, but Klbkch had participated in and suffered such gatherings before. The other Hives always sent spectators to witness another Hive's achievement. But this time...

Klbkch tried to modulate his breathing. It was no good. His hand trembled as it touched his swords.

He had heard the report from the Listeners. They had heard the other Antinium approaching of course, and monitored them closely. But it was only this close to the city that some details had emerged, details which had shaken Klbkch down to his core.

It was about one of the Antinium who travelled with the others, one who stood out. Klbkch looked at the report. He had written it down, circled the information after speaking with the Listeners. To be sure.

"An Antinium who casts magic?"

That was what the Listeners had heard. Explosions, thunderous sounds coming from her location. Spells, in short, unless the other Hives had managed to create a truly incredible variant in the few years since Klbkch had checked on them.

It had to be magic. And there was only one Antinium in the world who could cast spells. At least, only one Antinium among the living.

Klbkch sat in his chair. He held his silvery swords, stared blankly at a dirt wall. Only one Antinium, now. One that he had known since...since the day he had been created. So long ago.

The former Prognugator of the hive, the Revalantor named Klbkch, and the being who had once been one of the Centenium sat in the wooden chair. He stared back into the past.

And remembered.

They came into the city as the sun was shining overhead. Not Antinium—a group of Drakes. They walked through the southern gates, talking with the guard, hoods covering any distinctive details like armor. Perhaps they

would have entered quietly, but they were there to witness the monster attack.

It came out of the dungeon. The uncovered entrance to this new set of ruins was placed east of the city, at a good distance but close enough that the City Watch had posted a sizeable guard on the entrance.

Now this line of defense was under attack. The Drakes saw a band of Human adventurers fleeing the ruins, and behind them, shouts and screaming. Gnolls and Drakes fought desperately, the [Mage] among them shooting arrows of light into an oncoming crowd of—

“Children?”

That was what one of the Drakes in the group, a female adjunct whispered in horror. But these were no children who came pouring out of the hole in the ground, screaming, teeth bared.

“Scalelings.”

Wall Lord Ilvriss spat the words as Zel saw the line of guardsmen brace for impact. Arrows took down the horrible apparitions—shaped like children of Gnolls, Drakes, and Humans to lower their victim’s defenses—running at the [Guardsmen]. They normally preyed on people at night, he knew, where their monstrous details—their bright yellow, pupil less eyes and unnaturally long limbs for children were harder to pick out.

But the team of adventurers wearing poor-quality armor had upset their nest, and so it fell to the [Guardsmen] to stop them from attacking the adventurers and travelers on the road. They shouted as they hit the first wave, the small Scalelings—or Children as they were known in Human lands—pushing back the [Guardsmen] with terrible strength and ferocity.

“They’re going to be overwhelmed.”

Ilvriss said this calmly, a hand on his sword as the guards at the gate of Liscor sounded the alarm. There were [Archers] on the walls of course, but the battle was too thick for all but the best to shoot into.

“Should we cut a path for them to retreat to the walls, do you think, Shivertail?”

“No. Allow me.”

So saying, Zel pointed at the [Guardsmen]. He spoke two words.

“[Shield Wall].”

The [Guardsmen] had been faltering, falling back. But as Zel said the words, their actions changed. They stood taller, and when the snarling Scalelings rammed into them, it was the monsters who fell back. Suddenly,

each Drake and Gnoll was rooted in place and they forced the horrific creatures back one step at a time.

“Reinforcements.”

Ilvriss commented as more [Guardsmen]—[Guardspeople], really—rushed out the gate. For how quickly the engagement had started, their response was quite fast.

“And there’s the local [Tactician] I think. We can move on.”

“Mm. Yes.”

Zel nodded, seeing the battle was contained. He, Ilvriss, and the group the Wall Lord had brought with him walked further into the city.

“I’m not staying at the same inn as you, Shivertail. You can find whatever run down hovel you want, but I’ll be staying at the Tailless Thief. It’s the best inn in the city and I know the owner.”

“Fine by me.”

Zel didn’t rise to the bait. He looked around the city, noting all the Human adventurers who were gathered at the gates, watching the fighting.

“Lots of adventurers around. You might not find a room.”

Ilvriss just scowled at him.

“The innkeeper will make room. I am a Lord of the Wall.”

“Good for you.”

Zel would be glad enough to leave Ilvriss to his own devices—at least for a day. His feet hurt. He walked on through the city. Time enough to find an inn for himself later. Right now he had to announce himself to the Council with Ilvriss. The wretched Drake demanded such formailities.

So Zel Shivertail entered Liscor. And his arrival was unnoticed by many pedestrians, but the [Guardsmen] certainly noticed and word instantly spread to the Watch Captain of the incident. And one other person in the city noticed as well.

Selys looked up from her desk in the Adventurer’s Guild, cutting off her conversation with a wet and unhappy Gnoll. She suddenly felt lighter, and more refreshed, as if someone had given her a hot mug of tea. She made a fist with one claw, and then looked out the window with a smile. Only one person always included her in his radius of command.

“Oh. Uncle Zel’s visiting the city!”

Klbkch met the other Antinium outside of the city, in secret. He came alone, and nodded his head respectfully as the other Antinium stood, letting snow fall off of their bodies to greet him.

They were a little less than twenty in all. Klbkch noted each one as they introduced themselves. Four Hives had come. Four Hives had sent their best. The absence of the fifth troubled him, but—

“Prognugator Klbkch. I greet you as a fellow Prognugator. I am Tersk of the Armored Antinium.”

The first to make a move was a big Antinium with a form reminiscent of a Soldier. But he had only two arms instead of four, and his hands were proper ones. He was also wearing armor. Klbkch stared at the steel plate armor that covered his entire body and noted the specially-tailored metal plates that had been carefully crafted into a helmet. He nodded to the armored giant.

“I greet you Tersk. Although I am no longer a Prognugator but a Revalantor I will perform the duties of both while you are here. I see you have brought others of your hive.”

“Yes.”

The Prognugator said it simply. He indicated three other Antinium, all as tall as he was, all wearing armor. Klbkch noted that all of the Armored Antinium had weapons. A shield and mace in Tersk’s case—swords and a spear for the others.

“Allow me to extend my apologies for my error in your position.”

“The error is mine. I did not mention this detail to begin with.”

Klbkch and Tersk lowered their heads. That done, the Prognugator stepped back and another one came forwards.

“Revalantor Klbkch. I am Revalantor Pivr. I observe that your form has changed from the standard template assigned to this Hive. Has your Queen been creating variations of the Worker and Soldier form without authorization?”

This came from an Antinium smaller than Tersk, but no less striking. Jade-colored wings fanned outwards from the Antinium, and Klbkch saw not two but four sets of eyes on his head. Even his body was hunched, all the better for his two arms to use the twin daggers at his side. He also had poisonous spit Klbkch knew—the odor was unmistakable on the Antinium’s breath.

And he annoyed Klbkch. The Revalantor stared Pivr in the eyes, and spoke calmly.

“My form is unique to me, as befitting my status. I greet you, Pivr. Who have you brought to my Hive?”

Pivr turned, fanning his twin sets of wings out to show them off, Klbkch was sure.

“Six of my Queen’s warriors—five regular warriors and a heavy-combat variant have flown here to see what your Hive has wrought. We are the Flying Antinium. Witness us.”

Klbkch did see, and part of him was impressed. Five of the warriors did look like Pivr, but the last was a larger variant. Thick carapace plates obscured his body, giving him more the appearance of a walking tank. But he had wings as well, huge ones, and even a horn like a beetle with sharp prongs.

Yes, part of Klbkch was impressed. The other part was not. But he kept his words within and simply nodded to Pivr.

“I greet you.”

The other Revalantor hesitated, opening his mandibles as if he wanted to say something. But then Klbkch was walking forwards towards the last unique Antinium in the group. He felt like he was in a dream, but when he stopped in front of the slim, short Antinium with blue carapace who held a staff in one of her two hands, she was real.

So very real.

“Xrn.”

It was all Klbkch could say. The other Antinium—no Worker, no Soldier, but graceful and unique, her body different from any other—opened her mandibles to smile at him. Her eyes shone with a thousand colors, flickering with the mystery of magic. And her voice was soft, deep, commanding.

“Klbkch. It has been too long.”

“Yes. Far too long.”

It was all Klbkch could say, as if he had been transformed into one of the birds that spoke, a parrot. Xrn smiled again. Klbkch didn’t know what to say.

“How—how did you come here? I would have never thought the Grand Queen would allow...”

“I had to persuade her of course. But I thought it worthwhile to see you.”

Xrn said it simply. She nodded to the Soldiers and Workers behind her, and only now did Klbkch realize he was neglecting his duties.

“Pardon me. I greet you, Xrn, Prognugator of the Grand Hive. Who are the Antinium who come with you?”

“Two Hives. Mine, and that of the Silent Antinium.”

She pointed, and Klbkch saw. There were two groups standing behind Xrn, eight Antinium in total. Two were still as shadows, hunched, almost invisible even in the snow. Their carapaces had changed to become whiter, more translucent, and their arms were more like scything blades. Their mandibles were likewise made to tear out an opponent’s throat and they were perhaps the slimmest of all Antinium save for Xrn.

“The assassin breed. Have they no leader?”

“Their Queen declined to send one. And with me—six of the Grand Queen’s soldiers, my escort.”

These Antinium were by far the most conventional, but even then... Klbkch saw two were classic Soldiers, but with carapaces so heavily reinforced that they stood two feet taller than a regular Soldier, to carry all the weight. They were taller even than the Armored Antinium, while the other four—

Klbkch inhaled sharply. Xrn nodded.

“They are like me.”

Indeed, the four Antinium closely resembled Klbkch’s current form. They were slim and had two hands, and at their sides they had blades. Not silver metal like his, but rather blades made of a dark substance, the same as those the scythes of the Silent Antinium were made of. These Antinium were also different from the rest in that they studied Klbkch with attentiveness. Intelligence.

“Natural blades. These are not Prognugators but Custodium—think of them as partial Prognugators.”

“Made in the same way?”

Xrn’s mandibles opened, and her tone was mocking.

“Yes. There are forty in the Hive.”

The number left Klbkch speechless. The sheer extravagance and waste it took to create—he would have asked Xrn more, but then Pivr interrupted.

“Revalantor Klbkch, are the introductions done? If so, I have a pressing announcement to inform you of.”

Klbkch and Xrn stared at him. They were all Prognugators and Revalantors, true, including Tersk, but Xrn and Klbkch were different. Tersk clearly knew that and respectfully stayed quiet, but Pivr was clearly different.

Xrn was the first to speak. Her tone was sharp.

“I am talking with Klbkch. You will be silent, Pivr.”

“You have been given command of our group, yes. But my Queen—”

“Shut up.”

Xrn turned back to Klbkch and only now did he remember the... personality of his old companion. He had forgotten it, living for so long in his quiet Hive.

“We have much to discuss. After we greet your Queen, you and I must have time to talk.”

“You are not expected to return soon?”

“No. In fact, I told my Queen I would be a long time in returning.”

“You told the Grand Queen that?”

“Yes.”

That was Xrn. Klbkch shifted his glance to the Antinium and once again noted the absence of the fifth Hive.

“Wrymvr did not come? And his Queen sent no one?”

Xrn shrugged.

“You know him.”

“I do. I should not be surprised. In truth, I did not expect your presence either.”

“Yes, well—”

“I have an announcement.”

This time Klbkch had to restrain himself from stabbing Pivr. But the Revalantor had strode into the center of the Antinium. He spoke loudly, without glancing at Xrn whose look was...murderous.

“My instructions were to obey Prognugator Xrn until we reached the city of Liscor. However, here I and the Flying Antinium will carry out different orders. We will go into the city via the main gates.”

“What?”

Klbkch couldn't believe his ears. Pivr nodded at him calmly.

“I was not informed of this.”

Xrn's voice was foreboding, but Pivr didn't seem intimidated.

"Your input was not required. My Queen has given her orders, and they will be obeyed."

"You cannot enter the city. I forbid it."

Klbgch had no idea how the [Guardsmen] would react upon seeing these Antinium. They would likely think the Second Antinium Wars were upon them again. Even in the best case—

But Pivr could not be argued with.

"These are my Queen's orders. You, Xrn, have no authority over this. We will go into the city. We will not fight even if provoked, but we will maintain a show of force. You are allowed to follow us if you so desire. Indeed, Revalantor Klbgch's presence would greatly be appreciated."

With that, he and the other six Antinium began to march through the snow. They accelerated—then their wings opened and they *flew*.

Not into the air, but across the ground, skipping across the ground. It wasn't true flight—but it was too fast to catch up to on foot. Klbgch didn't waste time talking to Xrn. She couldn't stop them. If she cast a spell the Flying Antinium would fight it, and if she bound them they would just wait to be free. They would fulfill their orders or die.

The Antinium flew towards the city, and soon Klbgch heard the shouting from the walls. He only prayed there wouldn't be any fighting. So long as the [Guardsmen] kept their cool they would realize these were Antinium. And the citizens of Liscor had grown used to the Antinium. It could be okay. It might be okay.

Then he saw the two Drakes standing in the middle of the street. Pivr had stopped with his six Antinium, uncertain. Drakes and Gnolls and Humans were fleeing him, but these two Drakes—and the group of warriors standing behind them—were not.

Klbgch could sense they were no ordinary warriors. Their presence alone had warned Pivr not to approach carelessly. Klbgch looked at them, about to call out, defuse whatever misunderstanding that might have occurred. And then he recognized one of them.

Zel Shivertail had been prepared for the Antinium. He knew they were in the city so he had been prepared to grit his teeth if he saw one on the

street. But the flying Antinium? They'd come out of nowhere, speeding down the street. Was it an attack? His pulse had been racing and he had had to hold Ilvriss back, prevent him from unsheathing his sword and attacking.

But now another Antinium had come, one armed with two swords. Zel saw them, and his heart stopped in his chest.

Ilvriss froze by his side. His voice was the only sound in the street, the only sound Zel could hear over the hammering in his chest.

"Those swords. It can't be—"

Another Antinium raced into the city, and behind her, more Antinium. Armored warriors—huge giants! The Drake warriors behind Ilvriss grabbed at their weapons.

"Those are specialist Antinium! From the Hives in the south!"

"An attack!?"

"Guard the Wall Lord!"

"Hold—hold!"

Zel ground the words out, but he felt like he'd been stabbed. Ilvriss had gone pale at the sight of the other Antinium who stood by the one with swords. His voice was a whisper now.

"Azure. The color of the sky."

There was only one Antinium like that, Zel knew. But his eyes were still on the one with swords. There was only one Antinium like that one, as well.

"Klbkch the Slayer."

His voice was thunder in his ears as he let go of Ilvriss. The Wall Lord had a death-grip on his sword as he stared at the Antinium holding the staff.

"The Small Queen. Xrn."

Across the street, Klbkch stood frozen. Memory surged around him at the sight of Zel Shivertail's face. It had caught Xrn as well.

"Zel Shivertail. And a Lord of the Wall."

The air had changed. Pivr glanced uncertainly at Klbkch and Xrn.

"Who are these Drakes?"

No one answered him. Klbkch's hands were on his sword. He felt Xrn trembling next to him.

"We must not fight."

He said it, but the words were distant in his head. He couldn't retreat. Not here. Not now.

Someone took a step forwards. Was it him? The Drakes started to advance as well. Shivertail's eyes were locked on Klbkch's.

Memory flashed between the two.

Zel Shivertail killed another Soldier, cutting apart his carapace with claws like razors. He turned, and saw the battlefield had disintegrated into chaos. Drakes and Antinium struggled everywhere, the Antinium fighting and killing anything moving.

Chaos. He turned and blocked a sword that came for his neck at the last moment. The Antinium who leapt backwards was slim, and covered in blood. Drake blood. He held his swords like a true blade master, watching Zel carefully.

"Zel Shivertail."

"You must be Klbkch the Slayer."

"Yes. I have come to kill you. If you die, the Antinium will triumph here."

Zel pointed at the battlefield, where Antinium fought and died, killing mindlessly even as the Drakes organized and began to slaughter them.

"Is this how the Antinium do battle?"

"It is how we fight to survive, Drake. When we do battle, you will know the difference."

Klbkch leapt forwards and then there were only his flashing blades. Zel snarled, slashing with his claws—

"I'll take the mage. You take the Slayer."

"We are not...here to fight."

Zel rasped the words out. His feet dragged themselves forwards though, and he couldn't muster the effort to stop them. He and Ilvriss advanced down the street, ignoring the calls from the Drakes behind them to stop.

Ilvriss felt one of his guards grab at him and swung one fist. The Drake fell back, bleeding, and the Lord of the Wall walked forwards as if in a

trance. His sword was in his hand, and his eyes were on Xrn's. They stared at each other, as they had done years ago on the battlefield.

He stood with the [Mages] and [Strategists], coordinating the battle as the Drake and Human forces contained the Antinium with walls of steel and blasted them with magic. Ilvriss stood patiently, knowing his chance for battle would not come. But then the earth exploded and he saw her standing amid the destruction.

The command tent burned as she drew a line of fire that burned the Human [Commander] to ash. Out of the billowing smoke, Soldiers charged into battle, fighting the unprepared [Mages] and support classes and their small retinue of guards.

"This battle is over. Flee, Drakes and Humans, or I will slay you all."

That came from the Antinium who glowed with magic. She looked down at Ilvriss as he stood, shaking, blood running down his right leg, his long sword in hand.

"Name yourself! Who are you?"

He roared at her as he charged, cutting Soldiers down. The Antinium's voice echoed as she stood on a rock, casting spells left and right, cutting down his allies, his friends.

"I am the last memory of my kind. Thunder which moves grass. I am a Queen without a Hive. Fire burning in the heart of ice. I am Xrn, and I will not die here."

She raised her staff, and lightning split the sky. It broke the formations of Drakes, and a fireball fell among the [Mages] who hadn't time to raise a shield spell. They burned, dying, and the Antinium with a staff raised hers high. The wind blew, and the Soldiers and Workers charged. Ilvriss fell back, fighting among the dying....

He couldn't stop. Zel walked onwards, and so did the Antinium. The streets were empty.

The air was screaming with tension.

He knew he should stop. They were at peace.

Peace? With the Antinium? Zel walked the battlefield and saw his foes only a few feet away. He could smell the dead around him, and feel blood running down his side. The air was hot. Hot? It was the middle of summer, and the Antinium—

Zel felt snow crunching under his feet. He knew he was in Liscor, knew the war was over. But the pounding pulse in his head wouldn't die down. And the Antinium were right in front of him.

Klbkch's feet moved. His swords were in his hands.

"We must stop."

Xrn said that, dreamily. But he could feel magic gathering around her. Klbkch said nothing.

He couldn't stop.

"Fighting is prohibited."

Klbkch's head turned and Pivr quailed. He knew the other Antinium was right. But nothing could stop him. He was staring Zel Shivertail in the eye, and he knew it was time to finish things. The sword was cold in Klbkch's hand. He took another step, another—

And then someone rushed in front of him, arms spread wide. Klbkch raised his sword to cut the person—the Antinium down—

"Pawn!"

The blade stopped. Pawn stood in front of Klbkch, arms spread wide, and twenty Soldiers stood at his back. Xrn had paused too, surprised by the other Antinium's appearance.

"Revalantor Klbkch, I regret that we must bar your way."

Klbkch opened his mandibles to protest, to tell Pawn to *move* before Zel Shivertail cut him down from behind—when he saw the shouting on the other end of the street.

"Guardsmen! Form a line!"

Watch Captain Zevra—*Zevra* was there, forming a living wall like Pawn had with Gnolls and Drakes. They blocked off Zel and the Wall Lord from advancing, faces grim, shields raised as if they expected a fight.

The Drake [General] was staring at Watch Captain Zevra as she shouted at them to back up. Klbkch heard another voice then as well, a familiar one.

“Hey, old man Zel! It’s me, Relc! How’s it going? And who’s this guy?”

A big Drake waved excitedly at the head of the tense group of [Guardsmen]. Relc was enough of a distraction by himself. Klbkch felt the madness—the memory holding him loosen. He turned.

“Xrn.”

“I know. Let’s get out of here.”

She turned. The Antinium—the Armored Antinium, Pivr and his band of idiots, and the silent assassins and Xrn’s honor guard ran through the streets. The City Watch and the Drake [General] let them go. And in a few moments...

There was peace.

For now.

They had come close to war. Perhaps. Zel could only shudder at the thought as he walked out of Liscor’s gates. If they had fought, regardless of who had lived and died, what would have happened? Would it have been war right then? Would the Queen have done that?

If Ilvriss or he had died—Zel didn’t want to imagine it. His earholes still rang from Watch Captain Zevara’s shouting. It had been a miracle she’d gotten there in time.

He should have known better. Zel knew that. But he had seen Klbkch and memory—

He’d think on it later. It was late, after all the shouting and then the explanations and introductions had been done. Zel glanced at the sky and wanted nothing more than to find somewhere comfortable to sleep.

But all the inns were full, and he had no desire to stay under the same roof as Ilvriss. So Zel walked out of the city and towards a place he thought he remembered.

It was odd. The inn seemed closer than it should have been, and in the wrong place. But it was the only inn around, and so Zel knocked politely on the door and waited.

When it did open, he stared down in mild surprise at the girl who stared up at him with huge eyes. A young Gnoll cub appeared behind the girl and then darted away as Zel waited for her to speak.

“Um. Hello.”

“Good evening, Miss. Is the [Innkeeper] here by any chance?”

“Erin? No she’s...I’m sorry, please, come in!”

Zel entered, somewhat mystified. Erin? That was a female name, or so he thought. What had happened to the man? Had he retired?

Perhaps he’d gotten married and this was his daughter. Or just a [Barmaid]. Zel sat at a table, smiling without showing his teeth as the girl brought him a drink.

“Here’s some water. Honey water, actually.”

Zel’s nonexistent eyebrows rose as he sipped at the sweet drink. It was quite nice, and pleasantly hot.

“So the [Innkeeper] is gone? Will she be back tonight, do you know?”

“No I—she’s been gone for a while now. I run the inn while she’s—away. My name is Lyon. Lyonette.”

Odder and odder. But Zel still needed a place to sleep.

“In that case, may I ask if your inn is full Miss Lyon? I’m looking for lodgings and all of the inns in the city are crowded.”

“A place to—?”

The girl’s eyes widened as if she was surprised he wanted to stay here. And judging from the way the inn was so empty at dinnertime, that was probably justified. But Zel liked the feel of the inn. It had glass windows, flowers, and a lovely fire.

“If you wouldn’t mind, I’d like a room. I stayed here once before—I think it was here—a long time ago and I have fond memories of this place.”

“Oh. Well this inn was rebuilt...”

Zel blinked at Lyon. The girl blushed.

“I’m sorry. It’s a long story. But yes—we have plenty of rooms. If you’d like to stay here, I can offer you a very reasonable rate. But I’m afraid Erin—the [Innkeeper] is gone so I’m the only one who can serve you. I’ll do my best, but I’m not the best cook.”

“Well, as long as it’s edible I will be quite happy.”

Zel smiled reassuringly at Lyon, and she managed to smile back. He looked down as he felt a wet nose on his leg.

“And I see you’re not all by yourself. Who’s this?”

“Mrsha!”

The Human girl yelped and chased away the Gnoll. But she paused as Zel laughed, and smiled again.

“If you’re willing...then welcome. As I said, my name is Lyonette. This is Mrsha. Welcome...to the Wandering Inn.”

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When the Horns of Hammerad left the city of Remendia, it was, predictably, to a huge fanfare and celebration by the crowds lining the street. At this point, the four adventurers so highly lauded were well and truly sick of the entire affair.

“It’s not even as if there’s anything to cheer about. We’re *leaving*.”

Yvlon and Pisces nodded in dour agreement as they strode down the streets towards the gates. Ksmvr didn’t reply—he was busy waving. He seemed to enjoy it.

“There’s the wagon. Let’s get on.”

Ceria pointed, and the Horns of Hammerad piled onto the wagon outside of the city. The cheering faded a bit as the crowds realized that the illustrious adventurers, the heroes who’d conquered Albez, weren’t leaving on white stallions or riding away in a carriage.

They were taking a wagon, for good and practical reasons. But it was definitely less fancy and so the adventurers left the city with their eardrums mostly intact.

“Thanks for waiting. Are you headed directly to Celum?”

Ceria addressed the wagon driver, a woman who grinned at her as she flicked her reins to make the two horses begin plodding down the road.

“That’s right. I’ve got a bulk delivery of goods—crops, meat, and so on—that needs to get down there tonight.”

“Oh? Are you part of the Runner’s Guild?”

The woman clearly was no Runner, but the Guild sometimes hired slower modes of transport to deliver goods the old-fashioned way when there weren’t enough Runners or there was too much to carry. The wagon driver snorted gently.

“No—Merchant’s Guild. We handle all the mundane traffic. You’ll never see a Runner stoop to carrying this stuff. Of course, up north the damn Runner’s Guilds have bags of holding and so their Runners can still beat our prices. But this close to the south us [Merchants] and [Traders] have the monopoly on transport.”

The half-Elf nodded. It wasn’t like she’d asked for an explanation, but guild rivalries were a touchy thing. And the Runner’s Guild wasn’t exactly

popular—adventurers had their issues with them, as did [Merchants] and other groups like the Mage’s Guild and so on.

“Well, so long as we get to Celum before dark, we’ll be happy.”

“No fear of that. Truth be told, I wouldn’t be doing this run at all if you lot hadn’t decided to hitch a ride. All these Goblin attacks make it far too dangerous—but the Horns of Hammerad shouldn’t have any problems, right?”

Ceria could only smile crookedly at that.

“Hopefully we don’t see an army.”

So saying, she retreated back to the mostly-filled wagon. Pisces was sitting atop a bag of what was probably potatoes, Yvlon had made herself comfortable on some boxes that she wouldn’t squish, and Ksmvr was sitting with his legs dangling off the back of the wagon. Ceria joined Yvlon on the boxes.

For a while there was silence. The Horns of Hammerad were tired, if not physically so early in the day, then mentally. After a while though, Pisces felt compelled to break the silence. As always.

“What I fail to understand is why those fo—those confused denizens of Remendia—felt the need to cheer our departure. To what end? We are leaving, not arriving in splendor and triumph.”

Ceria sighed. But it was Yvlon who replied. She frowned vaguely at Pisces, but had no real rancor in her tone. She and Pisces might be fairly incompatible, but they were teammates now.

“We’re heroes to them, Pisces. Don’t tell me you’ve never dreamed of seeing a team of adventurers as a child? They wanted to give us a sendoff worthy of the heroes they thought we were. I’m almost ashamed that we disappointed their expectations.”

Pisces sniffed, but made no comment. Ceria just shrugged as she made herself more comfortable on her seat. She drew the wool cloak around her body closer to herself, shivering at the cold winter winds.

“At some point they’ve got to realize that even heroes are practical. Besides, it’s not as if we could afford a carriage or mounts. Not that Ksmvr would be able to ride a horse.”

Ksmvr looked up from his study of the landscape and nodded.

“That is correct. Thank you for noticing, Captain Ceria.”

“Don’t mention it.”

Pisces rolled his eyes and smirked, but Yvlon treated him to a disapproving glance and he swallowed the comment he was about to make. Instead he looked back towards the city, already growing distant as the wagon pulled itself down the road at a good pace. The driver might have had a Skill that allowed the horses to move faster, Ceria reflected.

“I wonder, would all those cheering people believe that we are destitute?”

Yvlon looked blank.

“Destitute?”

“Broke.”

Ceria sighed. Pieces could have used a simpler word, but then he wouldn't be Pisces.

“I doubt it. After all that coin we received, who'd believe that? But if we hadn't gotten this deal to guard the wagon in exchange for transport, we'd be walking right now.”

That made everyone go silent for a moment. Yvlon just sighed, and stared down at her arms. She wasn't wearing her plate armor—it had been too badly damaged to save and they hadn't had enough coin to buy more. Instead, she was wearing leather, except along her arms which were still fused with the silvery metal.

“Do you think we gave Ryoka too much coin?”

“Perhaps.”

Ceria stared at the snowy landscape as they passed by. In the distance, she saw a village filled with a few moving shapes.

“There's no such thing as too much gold when it comes to paying [Mages]. She'll need a lot to get accurate, speedy work done.”

“And we should have had enough to live comfortably if it weren't for those extortionate fees.”

Pisces put that in with a scowl. Yvlon looked unhappy as well.

“I know. We should have considered that, but neither Ceria nor I had ever heard of the Guild's taxes until this point.”

That was true. Ceria had been just as surprised as the others when they'd found out that the Adventurer's Guild demanded a ten percent cut of the spoils gained from a dungeon raid or a particularly lucrative assignment. It did seem like extortion in a way—the Guild already took a chunk out of every assignment they offered and made money from referring adventurers and selling their own products.

But on the other hand, membership in the Adventurer's Guild was free, and they did provide other services. So the Horns of Hammerad had reluctantly paid the steep fees, choosing to pay more coin rather than report the value of the artifacts they'd recovered and have that factored into the fee.

Still, it smarted and took a lot out of their hard-won savings of coin. And when they added the fees for hiring the [Blacksmith] and [Healer] to remove the metal from Yvlon's arm—not to mention the price of staying in the inn and eating so lavishly for the few days they'd been in the city—well, that was how the Horns of Hammerad found themselves back to square one.

Which was to say, broke. They had a few silver coins left, but all of their remaining coin and the valuable artifacts they'd found were with Ryoka, in the north.

Did Ceria regret gambling everything on her friend? A little bit, she had to admit. Still...

"Ryoka will get back to us soon, and she'll contact us when she's done with Lady Magnolia. She might be appraising our artifacts as we speak."

Yvlon looked slightly doubtful.

"If you say so. You know her best, Ceria. I only met her once before. She seemed honorable—but hotheaded. Are you sure she won't waste the coin or...make a mistake with it?"

Pisces and Ksmvr turned to look at Ceria as well. She blinked, realizing that none of the other adventurers in her group knew Ryoka that well, even Pisces. True, he'd healed her legs, but he didn't know her any better than the others.

"She is. Hotheaded, I mean. She's prickly and arrogant and she's not exactly easy to deal with all of the time. But she is brave, Yvlon. She went into the crypts to rescue me and she's certainly no coward. We can trust her. Calruz did, and you know he wouldn't trust anyone who wasn't totally honorable. Actually...Ryoka's a lot like a female Calruz."

Yvlon snorted at that, but Pisces and Ksmvr just exchanged a confused glance. Ceria's heart twinged as she realized...neither of them knew who Calruz was, either. Pisces probably didn't even recognize the Minotaur's name.

"Well, we'll wait for her then. She's a friend of Erin Solstice, so I suppose I shall place my trust in her capabilities."

That was Pisces' conclusion. He sat back on his bag of potatoes and shifted around for a moment. Then he looked at Ceria.

"On the topic of spoils however, I wonder. If you're not planning on doing any studying, why not lend me that spellbook, Springwalker? I'd only borrow it for the duration of the journey..."

"No."

Ceria paused as she opened her pack. She pulled out the spellbook, the burnt half of a spellbook rather, and opened it carefully to the first page. It was her greatest treasure, now, far more important than anything else she'd ever owned. Yvlon rolled her eyes and Ksmvr scooped up some snow as the argument between the two [Mages] resumed.

"Oh come now. I won't need it for long—and you get sick when reading while in motion. Let me see it."

"My spellbook, Pisces. That was the deal."

He scowled at her.

"But that—I only meant—"

"I get the first spellbook we find, in exchange for the ring. You agreed, and so this is mine. Deal with it."

Ceria stared down at the page filled with glowing words and symbols. She had no idea what it meant—like most high-level magical spellbooks, this one was written in a combination of regular text and magical formulas. However, the words that were meant to describe a spell's use and other details were written in a language Ceria didn't know. She could only try and decipher the magical instructions, which were written in a universal language for [Mages].

The trouble was...Ceria wasn't certain what tier the spell she was staring at was, but it was certainly far above her capabilities. So were all the spells in the book—the mage had obviously been extraordinarily high-level, and so the spells were the most complex Ceria had ever seen. She wasn't even certain of whether she was on the first page of the spell or midway through—that was how hard it was to understand.

"But this is completely unfair. If you compare such a trove of magical knowledge to the paltry ring—surely you understand my position. Springwalker, I implore you. We could study it together. Surely two minds are better than—"

Pisces stopped whining and ducked as Ceria pointed her skeletal finger. A snowball coalesced out of the air and shot past his ear. He sat up and

Ceria kept reading.

That was the Horns of Hammerad. They sat on the wagon, Pisces sulking, Ceria reading, frowning and chewing at her hair, Yvlon staring at the landscape and Ksmvr playing with the snow.

They had gone into Albez and made their way through a trapped dungeon. True, they'd nearly died and lost a lot of the treasure to the final trap, but they'd survived. And now they were...

What? Ceria frowned as she tried to concentrate on the spell. Were they better than they had been? They were teammates, now, that was certain. They'd faced death once, and so they were a stronger group.

But was that all? They'd actually lost a lot of combat strength, she felt. Yvlon was injured. She could still wield a sword, albeit with some stiffness, but her armor was gone and her arms would need a master-class [Healer] to fix. Or a spell, neither of which the Horns of Hammerad could afford.

They had a spellbook, but Ceria couldn't make heads or tails of it for the moment and she doubted that Pisces, genius though he was, would have better luck. Ryoka had their hard-won artifacts, and while they might turn out to be earth-shatteringly powerful, and while Ceria would eventually learn all the spells in the spellbook, it was all deferred rewards. Right here and now, they were no better than they had been. Worse, in fact.

And that was concerning for one reason. Ceria put down the book of spells, making Pisces look up, and voiced her concerns to her team.

"I know we agreed to escort Erin back to Liscor. But are we sure that's wise at the moment?"

The other three Horns of Hammerad looked up. None of them needed an explanation. Yvlon frowned as she ran her fingers across the smooth metal in her arms—the [Blacksmith] had helped sand the rough edges of the metal after she had cut most of it away, but it still had to be uncomfortable, especially in the cold.

"I don't know. Honestly, I wouldn't worry normally. We're more than capable of taking on any normal group of bandits or monsters, but all the rumors of Goblin armies we've been hearing recently have me worried."

Ksmvr nodded.

"If the reports of a Goblin Lord are true, we should be cautious. Even raiding parties sent out from such a force would number in the hundreds."

Ceria grimaced.

“I doubt Erin’s in danger in Celum, at least if the Goblin Lord’s main army isn’t there. Every city has enchantments on their walls and they can normally hold out for a while. I just don’t understand how Esthelm fell in a day. That makes no sense.”

Pisces just shrugged. He seemed less concerned than the others by the countless stories they’d heard of Goblins attacking villages and even towns and cities.

“Goblin Lords are notoriously powerful. If one is truly present—and I cast aspersions on the rumors of his existence—then he could well have overwhelmed the city’s defenses with a sneak attack. Either way, his army is not a concern—word will spread when it marches. Rather, we should be worrying about Goblin war bands, as Ksmvr has said.”

Yvlon nodded seriously.

“We might be able to escape or fend them off if we encounter them on the road—but that depends on how many spells you and Pisces know. Ksmvr and I can’t fight a horde like that. But what worries me is Erin herself. Would we then be taking her into danger, bringing her to Liscor, closer to where the Goblin Lord might be?”

Ksmvr nodded, but Pisces just smirked and Ceria had to laugh at the irony of the question.

“Liscor? Hah. It’s safer than Celum, Yvlon. Erin’s close enough that she could run into the city if a Goblin force came calling. And as for them getting past Liscor’s walls...not a chance. That city’s famous from the Antinium Wars—it’s withstood sieges from the Antinium and a [Necromancer] far more capable than Pisces.”

“I object. That statement is fundamentally correct, but flawed in its assumptions. I—”

“Shut up, Pisces. The walls of Liscor are high, and they’ve got far more powerful enchantments on them. So long as they actually close the gates, they’ll hold out during a siege for months at least. And there’s two Gold-rank teams in the city. With them on the walls, even a Goblin Lord would think twice before assailing the city.”

“I see.”

Ksmvr and Yvlon nodded. The female [Warrior] looked towards the horizon, still tapping her fingers on the metal in her arm.

“So it seems like we only have two things to worry about. How to get Erin to Liscor safely, and what we should do while we’re waiting for Ryoka

to contact us.”

Ceria nodded. But Ksmvr had something else in mind. He stared back at Remendia, now a distant spot on the horizon.

“Do you think there will be crowds cheering us in Celum? I enjoyed the ones in Remendia.”

Pisces made a dismissive sound of disgust.

“I hope not. So much noise gets on my nerves.”

He paused.

“Although...mindless adulation is not without its merits. We should expect at least a small gathering; word will have spread of our exploits and no doubt there will be a commotion when we are recognized.”

“True, let’s just get through it as best we can.”

Yvlon smiled crookedly, but Ceria thought she looked a bit pleased at the idea. For her part, the half-Elf considered that she wouldn’t mind the attention. It was inconvenient of course after a while, but...

“Just so long as it doesn’t get to our heads. Fame is fleeting as adventurers, let’s not forget that.”

“Certainly not.”

“I will commit this to memory.”

“Indeed.”

The Horns of Hammerad settled back in their cart, nodding to each other. They fell into silence once more, waiting, contemplatively staring at the horizon towards the city of Celum, still invisible in the distance. The only sound was a snort that came from the wagon driver as the horses plodded onwards through the snow.

There were no cheering crowds in Celum, nor any parades, much to the disappointment of all the Horns of Hammerad. In fact, no one even batted an eyelid when the adventurers made their way through the gate.

“The Horns of Hammerad? Hm. Your name sounds familiar. You have anything to declare? No? Move on through, then.”

Dismayed, the adventurers walked past the first guard at the gates. It wasn’t as if they’d expected a huge reception. But how come no one had noticed their party’s name? Usually the exploits of adventuring teams were all gossiped about fiercely in all the local cities.

Either word hadn't spread yet, or no one cared about a Silver-ranked team of adventurers, no matter what they'd done.

Then again...it did seem like the [Guardsmen] manning the gate had a lot on their minds. They all looked sleep-deprived, as if they'd been pulling two shifts instead of one.

Ceria stopped to talk to one of them in the gatehouse. He was mumbling to himself in a corner of the room—she hesitated as she drew near and heard what he was saying.

“To sleep: perchance to dream: ay, there's the rub;
For in that sleep of death what dreams may come
When we have shuffled off this mortal coil,
Must give us pause: there's the respect
That makes calamity of so long life...”

Was he really that sleep-deprived? There was an odd cadence to his words. Ceria paused, wondering if she should find someone else to talk to, but she interrupted the man's rambling self-reflection anyways.

“Excuse me, guardsman.”

He jumped and stared at her. His eyes were bloodshot, and the scraggly mustache on his face could have used some trimming.

“I'm sorry, can I help you Miss...?”

He noticed her robes and her hand. To his credit he only stared for a few seconds.

“Are you an adventurer? Do you have anything to report? Monsters? Or something to declare?”

“No. I was just wondering. Is there any news? Any bad news?”

“About what?”

The fuzzy-lipped man blinked at her.

“The Goblins.”

He blinked a few more times before the words trickled into whatever part of his brain was still thinking. For some reason he took a pose.

“‘There is nothing either good or bad, but thinking makes it so.’ Ah... no, Miss. The Goblins haven't shown up near Celum.”

“I see. Thank you.”

Ceria backed away from him and rejoined her group. Pisces twirled one finger around his ears as he gestured at the guardsman. Ceria just shrugged

and led them into the city.

“Now, where’s Erin? Ryoka told me she was staying at a room in... which inn was it?”

“The Frenzied Hare, I think.”

It was a surreal experience, walking through a city where no one stared at them or came over to talk or shake their hands. Were the adventurers disappointed? Yes, a little bit, but at the same time it felt good to be normal again.

They were no heroes, and while they liked to be treated as one, it wasn’t why they’d become adventurers in the first place. True, many young men and women of every species joined for exactly that reason; to become rich and famous. But after they spent their first week shivering in the mud and rain while insects crawled all over them, or come face-to-face with a monster with too many teeth, such people usually quit.

True adventurers, Ceria reflected, wanted something other than just fame and fleeting fortune. Although that was a nice side-effect of success.

It wasn’t hard to find the Frenzied Hare. For some reason everyone the Horns of Hammerad asked could tell them exactly where the inn was.

“Going to see the night’s show? Good luck! I had to stand throughout the entire thing, although I’ll say it was worth it.”

“I’d go back again, but I’ve work early the next day. Maybe when the next play comes out...”

These remarks meant nothing to the Horns of Hammerad, but it reinforced Ceria and Pisces’ belief that Erin was staying at the inn.

“After all, if something strange is going on that girl probably had something to do with it.”

Ceria nodded at Pisces’ comment and both Yvlon and Ksmvr were forced to agree. That was how they found themselves pushing the door to the inn open just before the sun set over the rooftops in the city.

To their surprise, the humble-looking inn was *packed*. The Horns of Hammerad opened the door and were treated to a heaving room full of people, crowding every table, talking, eating, so many that the adventurers had to edge carefully into the room to avoid stepping on toes.

It was a strange, surreal sight. The guests sat in eager groups, people who looked like they didn’t even know each other, willingly sharing tables and talking excitedly about the night’s play. It was an odd word they used.

‘Play’. They spoke of it as if it were something different, or a magical word, and it made the Horns of Hammerad glance at each other in confusion.

More aspects of the inn didn’t make sense. For instance, why was there a curtain on one end of the room? There was a good third of the common room that had no tables on it—why was no one sitting there? Ceria stared around, wondering what was going on.

“Do you see anywhere to sit?”

“There.”

Ksmvr spotted a table that was empty and immediately walked towards it. The other five patrons who’d been making a beeline for the table stopped when they saw the Antinium approaching and backed away. Ceria went to sit as well, but she and the other adventurers were stopped by a somewhat stout woman who came rushing over, waving her hands.

“Stop, stop! Please, I don’t know who you are—but even if you *are* adventurers, I’m afraid all the seats are taken. You’ll have to stand like the rest. You can’t just take over a table...”

She looked nervous, especially when she stared at Ksmvr, but she also sounded like she was ready to chase Ceria and the others away even if they protested.

“Sorry, Mistress. We didn’t know—what’s going on?”

Ceria waved at the crowds. The [Innkeeper], if that was who she was, looked surprised.

“You don’t know? Aren’t you here for the night’s play?”

“What play? You mean with toys? We’re here to see a friend. Erin Solstice. Do you know if she’s staying here?”

The woman’s eyes widened in shock. She glanced back at the kitchen.

“Erin? You want to meet—I’m so sorry, but she’s busy. Cooking. I’ll let her know you asked about her, but if she doesn’t keep working we’ll never get this crowd fed. If you’ll wait until tonight I’m sure—”

Pisces rolled his eyes. Fed up with the woman, he brusquely marched past her and towards the kitchen. She tried to stop him, but Ceria and Yvlon walked past her too.

“Erin?”

Ceria shouted into the open kitchen where the sounds of extreme cooking could be heard. She waited as the woman protectively barred the doorway.

“Erin? Are you in there? It’s me. Ceria! And Yvlon is here as well. We —”

The half-Elf heard a shout from inside the kitchen. A moment later a young woman practically ran the older innkeeper over. She shoved the protesting woman aside and then turned to the Horns of Hammerad. Erin Solstice, covered in flour, sweat, and a strange red paste Ceria vaguely recognized as tomato sauce spread her arms wide and rushed at her friends.

“Ceria! Yvlon!”

She practically tackled the two women, hugging them fiercely. Ceria laughed as people turned and looked, and Yvlon smiled as she gave Erin a welcoming hug. The girl turned, her eyes widening as she smiled.

“Ksmvr! And...you.”

She paused when she got to Pisces.

“Hey, you.”

He sniffed, hurt, but then Erin smiled and hugged him as well, much to the young man’s astonishment.

“You’re all okay! And alive! And—”

Erin saw Yvlon’s arms and gasped in shock. Yvlon opened her mouth to explain, but then the innkeeper was interrupting, trying to pull Erin back towards the kitchen.

“You know these adventurers, Erin dear? Can’t you have your reunion later? Folks are calling out for food!”

“They can wait. You cook if we’re so busy! Or get another inn to serve food! Shoo!”

Erin shoved the innkeeper away and then turned back to her friends. She stared at them, looking almost teary-eyed with relief.

“What happened? I was so worried! Ryoka only said—well, she left a message for me that you were in Remendia! Did you find the dungeon? She said you cleared it—”

Their reunion was attracting stares. Only naturally—Ksmvr might have been allowed into the city, but he was still an Antinium, and Yvlon’s arms were getting their own attention. It didn’t take long for people to put two and two together, even as excited as they were for this ‘play’.

“The Horns of Hammerad! The Conquerers of Albez!”

A huge cheer went up, although half of the guests probably didn’t even know what it was about. This was a crowd that would cheer anything, but

soon there were people surrounding the Horns of Hammerad, talking excitedly.

At precisely the wrong time. Ceria, Pisces, Yvlon, and Ksmvr found themselves mobbed, and after a few minutes of chaos, Ceria managed to duck into the kitchen with Erin.

“You’re famous!”

That was what Erin said when they had a moment to speak. The hubbub was muted through the door, and Ceria sat against a kitchen counter, breathing heavily.

“Yeah, I guess. It’s still surprising—how are you *here*, Erin? The last time we met, you were in Liscor, nearly a hundred miles away from here! What’s this Ryoka said about Toren? Is there a problem?”

Erin’s face fell for a second. She turned around and Ceria noticed she was making food. Strange, circular sheets of dough slathered with pasted tomatoes and covered with cheese and meat. Ceria had eaten this food before, but it was still weird to her. What was it called again? Pizza?

“Yeah. He—it’s complicated. I’m making pizzas right now—sorry, I’ve got to keep working. But it’s great to know you’re okay. Except Yvlon! What happened to her arms?”

“It’s a long story.”

Ceria watched as Erin took a completed pizza—golden brown cheese glistening on top of the baked bread—out of the stone oven. Her stomach rumbled, and Erin laughed.

“You’re hungry! Well, good, because I’m making a ton of food! And you’re just in time! The play’s about to start! Oh, right—you don’t even know what’s happened. Well, just wait and see! You can watch it tonight. I’ll make Agnes get a table for you—unless you have another inn you’re staying at?”

The girl took a knife and diced the pizza up into gooey sections of eight which she placed onto plates. She turned to Ceria, smiling hugely.

“Why not stay here instead? But you’re probably staying at the best inn—that’s okay! I can visit you and besides, the beds here aren’t *that* great. But you should stay for dinner! It’ll be fun, I promise!”

Embarrassed, Ceria had to interject. She coughed as she confessed to Erin.

“We don’t uh, actually have the coin to stay at a good inn, Erin. We were hoping you could...”

The girl's eyes widened in shock.

"You didn't get *any* money from going through the dungeon? That's terrible! Everyone was saying how great it was, but adventuring doesn't pay, huh? You can stay at my inn—I mean, the inn I'm helping to run! Free of charge! I'll be making pizza tonight and I'll make a huge breakfast tomorrow!"

Ceria would have liked to protest, but she and the other Horns of Hammerad really didn't have any room to argue. She could only smile and hug Erin. The other girl hugged her back, tightly. They stood in silence for a moment, countless words unspoken, just happy to see each other again.

Then the door opened and let in spilling noise and confusion. Erin turned back to her cooking after giving the distressed woman named Miss Agnes orders, and Ceria and the other Horns of Hammerad found themselves seated just in time to witness a play.

What was it? The Horns of Hammerad sat at a table right in front of the stage, staring in confusion at the men, women, and one female Drake all dressed up as if they were [Lords] and [Ladies]. They strutted about the stage, and then one began to speak. He declaimed to the audience, who went magically silent as they watched him, only pausing to eat the hot pizza and sip from their mugs.

And then...two Humans, a man and a woman, both dressed as [Guardsmen]—Ceria thought they actually *were* [Guardsmen]...met in the center of the stage. One called out to the other, who stood at clear attention.

"Who's there?"

The woman on watch turned and put her hand on her sword, frowning deeply.

"Nay, answer me: stand, and reveal yourself."

A briefest pause, and then the man cried out.

"Long live the [King]!"

The woman palpably relaxed. She took her hand away from her sword.

"Bernardo?"

The man nodded as he approached.

"He."

What happened? One second the two were talking, and Ceria was wondering what in the name of fungus was going on, and then—

And then the play began. The Horns of Hammerad stared at the actors as they began to act, and realized as they were sitting what that word meant.

Acting. Telling a story. Of course they'd heard of performers and storytellers and even the occasional reenactment of an event, but this? This was different. They sat in stunned silence as on the stage of the Frenzied Hare, the people in silly costumes came to life and told a story.

For Ceria's part, she sat with a slice of hot pizza in front of her, chewing slowly and relishing the new taste. She tried to follow the performance on stage. What was this about some kind of revenge plot? Apparently the character – some [Prince] with an odd Human name – was trying to avenge his dead father, who'd come back as a ghost to ask him to slay his killer.

Human [Kings] and [Princes] and betrayal and death. Ceria had trouble keeping up with the plot in truth, but she felt mired by the sheer depravity of it all. The people on stage backstabbed and poisoned each other, dragging all down into death in the end.

It reminded her of Terandria, actually, and the rumors she'd heard of the games of politics played by each nation. She didn't *like* the premise of the play, but she couldn't look away. And the food was good.

But if she was the least-riveted by the performance, the same could not be said for Pisces. The instant the play began the mage was fixated, to the point where he actually stopped eating and just focused on the play.

He sat hunched forwards, eyes intent on each character as they spoke. Occasionally Pisces would sit back and nod his head or shake it sadly as they delivered complex verses in Shakespearean prose, or roll his eyes and smirk when a joke was spoken that passed over the audience's head.

To Ceria's right, Yvlon sat tensely in her chair, just as gripped by it. She was entranced too, although in her own way. Yvlon frowned when the premise of the play—a [Lord] who had slain the rightful [King] married the [Queen] to usurp the throne—was revealed. Thereafter she sat rigid in her seat, clearly rooting for the main character of the play to uncover the truth and bring down the traitorous villain.

And on the other side of the table? Ksmvr sat still, his slice of pizza drooping in his hand, staring as the tragedy unfolded. He seemed fascinated rather than emotionally moved, but Ceria didn't see him look away once.

She suspected a lot of what was going on was passing right over—or perhaps between—the antennae on the top of his head. But he was a keen observer nonetheless, and sat almost completely still as he watched the play reach its conclusion.

When it was over, when the young [Prince] lay dying and the rest of the cast lay sprawled out on the floor and his friend called out an end to the sorry tale, the audience leapt to their feet. They cheered the actors who stood and bowed repeatedly, and only then did Ceria find out the name of the play. She had missed it when getting her pizza, but now the name of the play was on everyone's lips as they talked excitedly about the story and called for more food and drink.

It was called Hamlet.

It was close to midnight before the inn finally cleared. The people left, most drunk and almost all half-asleep on their feet. The [Actors] had already left. Ceria had seen one of them—the [Guardsmen] with the fuzzy mustache who'd played Hamlet—stumbling off, looking partly dead. She wondered how he could work his job and act like this every night.

The [Innkeeper] Miss Agnes and the staff of [Barmaids]—four of them, all needed to keep up with the crowds—had long since retired. Only Erin remained. She sat in the messy room, looking exhausted and happy. And with her sat the Horns of Hammerad.

There was a different kind of feel to the air as they sat, talking quietly and eating the leftover pizza Erin had made. The excitement from the play had gone—Pisces had asked Erin many questions about it, as had Ksmvr. She'd told them all about the first few performances of the tale of Romeo and Juliet, and how it had changed the city.

The play was a new, amazing thing. The tale enacted on stage was a classic. After the first night, the new [Actors] had put on repeated performances, each time filling the Frenzied Hare to the brim with eager, paying guests. Other inns had immediately tried to entice the performers to their inns, but the troupe had stayed here.

And of course, where success came, countless people followed, wanting to perform the play themselves, become [Actors]...Erin told the amazed Horns of Hammerad that other groups were already imitating the play, and even going to other cities to perform.

But the [Actors] with the highest levels were by far Wesle and Jasi and the original crew of people who kept performing. They had already gained a handful of Skills and they had been bitten repeatedly by the acting bug. So

Erin had taught them another play, Hamlet, which they were performing each night to great success.

“I just don’t know what I’m going to do. They want to learn all the plays! And they said they want to create a travelling performance—just like Shakespeare did! It’s so wild!”

“Who’s Shakespeare? The one who wrote this play? Where does he live? Can I meet him?”

Pisces chewed the crust of the pizza furiously as he stared at Erin. Ksmvr was busy eating some raw dough—he was obsessed with the stuff, and only he could eat it with the charm against food poisoning. Erin just waved Pisces away, shaking her head.

“He’s long dead. And besides—there’s just so much to do! I’d like to stay, but doing these plays is *exhausting*! I can teach Wesle and the others the plays I know—some of them have [Perfect Recall] like me. But I just wanted to show them a play, you know? I didn’t expect it to get this *big*.”

“Forget famous. This will sweep across the world.”

Ceria sat back in her chair, amazed at the idea. She could already see the play becoming a huge hit in Terandria. Why, every [Lord] would want to put on a performance. How much money could be made from it? She couldn’t even imagine what would happen next.

Erin just shrugged. She hadn’t wanted to talk about the play at all. She stared at Yvlon’s arms again as the woman dozed in her chair.

“I can’t believe what happened to you guys. You’ve been through so much. And Ryoka...I thought she would come back with you.”

“I think she’s okay.”

Ceria tried to reassure Erin. She honestly had no idea what Ryoka was going through, or why she’d attracted the attention of Magnolia Reinhart, but Erin looked worried.

“She’ll be fine. She’s tough. And she has that Frost Faerie with her.”

“Oh yeah! Ivolethe!”

The young woman brightened up, as if having a Frost Faerie follow you around was a good thing. She stared at the others and sighed.

“I’m just so glad you’re alright. So glad. I was worried.”

Ceria smiled slightly guiltily at Erin.

“We did it. It cost us a lot, but we did it.”

Pisces and Ksmvr nodded. Yvlon blinked and nodded as well, automatically.

“What—yes. Yes we did. And we have come here to repay the debt.”

“Not that we have any gold to pay you with.”

Pisces’ sardonic remark made Erin wrinkle her nose at him.

“I don’t care about that! I’m just glad you’re okay. Besides, Ryoka has all your stuff, right? When she comes back you can give me coin. Or a magical sword. That would be cool. Or the bag of holding! That would be so useful!”

“We owe you a great deal. We’ll find something worth repaying you with, even if it’s only a bucket full of gold.”

Ceria meant every word. Without Erin’s help they would have never had the coin to get to Albez, let alone found Ksmvr and joined up the way they had. Erin smiled, and then looked wistfully towards the window.

“And now that you’re here, you’ll help me go back, right? To Liscor?”

The others at the table sat up. Pisces cast a glance towards Ceria and she hesitated.

“I think we can. But it’s dangerous.”

“That’s okay. I’m used to danger.”

No one could disagree with that. Even so, Ceria hesitated. She looked around the inn. It was still messy, but it was a nice place, in its own way.

“Are you sure you couldn’t stay here? At least for a month or two? Celum isn’t bad.”

Erin looked at Ceria seriously.

“No, it isn’t bad. But Celum...it’s not Liscor, you know? All my friends are in Liscor—well, you’re here but you know what I mean. But my inn’s there, and so is Mrsha and Lyon and...I have to go back. Even if it’s dangerous. You get that, right?”

The half-Elf breathed out slowly as Ksmvr nodded across the table.

“I believe I do. We do. And we’ll help you get back, but we’ve got to be careful. But Erin, there’s one thing you haven’t talked about. How did you get here?”

Erin had been smiling at Ceria, but now her smile vanished in a flash. She looked down at the crumbs in the plate and drew a finger through them.

“Toren.”

Next to Ceria, Pisces sat up, looking suddenly alert and slightly worried. Ceria scooted closer to the table, staring at Erin.

“Yeah. Ryoka mentioned him. What about your skeleton, Erin? What happened?”

The girl looked at Pisces.

“He’s your creation, isn’t he? Can you tell where he is now?”

Pisces hesitated, then shook his head.

“I’m not linked to him at the moment. I can sense him, but only vaguely. He’s...to the south, a good distance away.”

“Okay. That makes sense. It...matches with what I’ve heard.”

Erin’s face was troubled. Ceria saw Yvlon staring at Pisces and the way the mage stared hard at Erin’s face.

“What did my creation do, exactly?”

“I’ll tell you all I know. But it—it makes no sense.”

Briefly, Erin told the adventurers everything that had led up to her arriving at Celum. Ceria watched Pisces’ face. It changed only a little as Erin spoke, but when she talked about Toren disappearing he glanced down at his hands.

“I don’t know what happened. I just fell asleep...and then I was all the way over here. Toren must have dragged me here in the sled when I slept. But he left me in the middle of nowhere.”

“I see.”

The Human [Mage] tapped the table, seeming to think. He looked... slightly worried, Ceria thought, and a foreboding feeling appeared in her chest.

“Pisces. What happened to Erin’s skeleton?”

“I have a number of theories but...it would be best to collect more information first. Miss Erin, have you heard anything else of your skeleton?”

Erin nodded, and now she looked...sad. Terribly sad.

“I kept asking Wesle—the [Guardsmen]—about him. At first there was nothing. But...the other day he told me a skeleton on the road was attacking people. He killed a bunch of travelers and buried them in the snow. A group of adventurers nearly got killed by him, and afterwards they found all the dead people. Over twenty of them.”

All four people in the room stared at Pisces. He raised his hands defensively.

“I didn’t order him to do that!”

“Well then, what the hell happened!?”

Ceria stood up in her chair. She pointed a finger at Pisces, who flinched.

“That sure sounds like your spell failing! Did Toren lose control somehow? Why did he start killing people?”

“I don’t know. I have an idea but—”

“That’s not all.”

Erin interrupted the two. They stared at her. Erin stared at them in the darkness, her face only lit by the few candles burning low in the inn.

“There’s more. A bunch of reports just came from Esthelm.”

Yvlon stirred in her seat, looking confused.

“Esthelm? I thought it was destroyed.”

Erin nodded.

“It was. But apparently a bunch of people survived. They managed to retake the city—they fought off another army of Goblins and a bunch of undead. Apparently, a Goblin army came by just as all the dead in the city began to rise. And the dead were being led by a skeleton. One who could fight like a swordsman and had purple eyes.”

Pisces froze in his seat. Ceria stared at him, but Erin wasn’t looking at either of them.

“The people apparently were being led by this [Knight] guy. He saved them. Everyone’s talking about him. The Savior of Esthelm. A Gold-rank adventurer named Ylawes Byres.”

Yvlon froze in her seat, eyes wide. Ceria stared at her.

“Is that a relative of yours, Yvlon?”

She vaguely remembered the name from somewhere. Where? Then Ceria remembered.

The pit. The pit of insanity. At one point Yvlon had claimed to be Ylawes. Now the woman closed her eyes. When she opened them, she smiled ruefully.

“I know Ylawes. He’s my older brother. He must have journeyed south to see me. He normally works far to the north, around our family estates.”

Everyone stared at Yvlon. She just shrugged, tired.

“Surprised? I’m only a Silver-rank, but my brother’s quite famous up north. His team—the Silver Swords—often take up causes like this one. Esthelm’s just another one of his triumphs.”

“I’ve heard of the Silver Swords.”

It wasn’t as if Ceria knew all of the adventurer teams by heart, but the Gold-rank ones tended to stick in one’s memory. But she’d never known Yvlon had a brother. Then again, she’d never asked. It was surprising to say

the least, but Yvlon didn't seem to want to talk about her brother at the moment. She looked at Erin.

"Putting aside my brother...you said Toren was spotted at Esthelm?"

Erin nodded unhappily.

"Yeah. Leading the undead. They killed a lot of people. The attacking Goblins too, but a lot of people. It was definitely him."

She looked at Pisces, helplessly.

"Why did he do it? Why did he run off and..."

All eyes were on the mage. He shifted in his seat, looking uncomfortable. Twice he glanced at Ceria, but then he sighed and sat up in his chair.

"Numerous theories come to mind. He could have been controlled, or simply gone rampant if my spells failed. However, both outcomes are unlikely in the extreme. My best theory is that he simply...grew too powerful for your commands to control him. And he decided to go his own way."

"How?"

The word came sharply from Ceria. She stared at Pisces, heart beating faster.

"Toren's just a skeleton, isn't he?"

She remembered the skeleton's gaze, almost intelligent. Almost alive. Pisces hesitated.

"He may have developed the capacity for thought."

"*Toren?*"

Erin looked incredulous. So did Yvlon. Ksmvr just stared silently at Pisces as the mage nodded.

"It can happen. Revenants retain the personality of their former selves. Toren is no Revenant of course, but he could have gained the...ability to think."

"Gained."

The word was heavy on her tongue. Ceria couldn't look away from Pisces.

"You keep using words like that. Gain. Grew. But the undead can't grow. They're not alive. They can't change unless a [Necromancer] alters them in some way. Nothing can. Unless they can level."

Pisces stared past Ceria. Silent. Unmoving. Ceria's pulse was thunder in her ears. She remembered the past. She remembered Wistram, and she gave

voice to her fears.

“Toren couldn’t have changed. Unless you did it. You actually did it. You gave him, an undead, the ability to level.”

Erin’s eyes grew wide across the table. Yvlon sat up straight, and even Ksmvr grew shocked. Ceria just stared at Pisces. He looked ahead, face emotionless. Then, slowly, the façade broke. His lips turned up. He looked at Ceria.

And smiled.

“*You bastard!*”

Ceria leapt from her chair. She knocked Pisces out of his seat, and slung him to the ground. He gasped as she put her hands around his throat and tried to choke him. Ceria felt him push her hands off him as Pisces backed away, speaking quickly, urgently.

“I didn’t know he would gain any type of sentience! His capability to level up was only meant to be a feature, nothing more!”

“You *knew!* You gave Erin an undead that could level! Are you *insane!?*”

Ceria pursued Pisces, ready to punch his brains out. To her surprise, hands grabbed her. Ksmvr used three of his to hold her, and Yvlon grabbed her other arm. Erin was just sitting at the table, looking blank and shocked.

“Yvlon!”

“Calm down, Ceria. We need to know just what Pisces did before you beat him to a pulp.”

The look in the woman’s eyes clearly said a beating was in order either way. Pisces gulped, but began to explain. He was too eager to do so. Ceria glared at him across the table as the [Necromancer]’s eyes lit up as he told the group what he had done.

“Yes, Ceria is right. I created an undead that could level. Toren, as Erin named him. He was just an experimental prototype—something meant to repay her and guard her inn. But I wanted to see if he could level as well, so I gave him to Erin. I never expected him to gain sentience, though.”

“He can think?”

Erin stared at Pisces, looking horrified. He hesitated, and then nodded.

“He must be able to, to abandon you and do what he has done. Had you noticed him taking independent action or...questioning your orders?”

“I didn’t—I thought it was just him being weird. But now...”

Erin stared at her hands, blinking.

“I—yeah. He did. He was acting so odd lately and I was going to bug you about it. He can think? He’s alive?”

“And he can level.”

Ceria glared at Pisces. He edged away from her, but it was Yvlon who spoke. The woman looked deeply troubled.

“How? How is that possible? I’ve never heard of a leveling undead, ever. Not even the greatest [Necromancers] could make one.”

“More like none of them were crazy enough to try. Any undead that can level will eventually rebel, just like Golems.”

Ceria glared at Pisces. The young man raised his hands, looking nervous but elated.

“I told you it was possible. I told them all at Wistram. Toren was proof I could do it. But I never expected him to level up quickly enough to subvert my control. I did check, you know, whenever I saw him.”

“Not well enough. Look what’s happened!”

“How, though?”

Ksmvr was the one to speak. He stared at Pisces, looking troubled.

“Is comrade Pisces truly that great of a prodigy? Or is his level high enough that he is able to create such a miraculous undead through some Skill?”

The half-Elf shook her head, smiling darkly.

“He didn’t learn how to make leveling undead by himself. He’s not that smart.”

Pisces opened his mouth and then shrank back in his chair as everyone glared at him. Ceria explained.

“A Golem taught him. A Truestone Construct; one of the most powerful types of Golems in the world taught him an incomplete formula for creating beings capable of leveling up. And he—completed it.”

“So you made a thinking, leveling undead.”

Yvlon’s eyes could have bored a hole through the mage. He shook his head.

“I was taught a theoretical piece of magic, it’s true. But it’s still not perfect. It wasn’t even certain my creation—Toren—would be able to level.”

“But he did. And he learned to think!”

“Evidently.”

Pisces stared uncomfortably at Erin, and then away. She had a haunted, horrified look on her face.

“I made him do chores. But he could think the entire time?”

“Erin...”

Ceria reached out and touched her friend. Erin shuddered, and then stared at Pisces angrily.

“Okay, he was alive. But why did he start killing people? I never told him to do that! He just did chores for me!”

Pisces spread his hands out, helplessly.

“He probably wished to. I can only speculate, but as I told you once, Toren is not meant for peaceful activities. He may have rebelled out of his desire to fight.”

“Why? He’s not evil! I mean—he wasn’t made that way, right? All he did was do chores! How could he just kill like that?”

Erin tried to snap her fingers, but couldn’t. She was trembling. Pisces closed his eyes, when he opened them, he looked regretful for a moment.

“It is what he was made to do. You see—I made him to fight, to protect. I imbued him with the capability for rational thought in the fashion of Golems. Problem-solving skills; but nothing more, certainly not a groundwork for actual cognition. But I never gave him anything else.”

Erin turned towards Ceria. The half-Elf crossed her arms.

“He didn’t give him a conscience. Or...morality.”

“What? Why not?”

Pisces shrugged eloquently at Yvlon. She clenched her fist, and Ceria interjected.

“He can’t. He doesn’t know how.”

“Then why make a creature like that? You’re just inviting trouble!”

Ceria wasn’t about to defend Pisces on that. He just looked at her, though, haughty and unrepentant.

“Cognita has no moral compass. She functions well enough without one.”

“She’s a monster too. She’s killed more [Mages] than any other being in the world, I’ll wager. She might be helpful to some, but you know she’ll kill without a qualm as well.”

Pisces nodded reluctantly, but he still didn’t appear convinced what he’d done was wrong. Remorseful, yes, guilty, even. But he looked like he had when he stood in front of the Council of Wistram the day they’d exiled him.

He was certain, and it made Ceria sick because at least in some way, he was right.

He'd done it. He'd actually done it. She could hardly bear to look at him.

Pisces turned back to Erin. The young woman was pale. She looked like she was about to vomit. The [Mage] modulated his tone, spoke softly and, for Pisces, gently.

"Let me be clear, Erin. This was not your fault. The error lay with me in underestimating the capability of my creation. Toren was a loyal servant until he grew strong enough to break the orders you and I had given him. Now he is a threat."

"A killer. He killed people. Men. Women. Children. But he's also like... a baby, isn't he?"

"An odd way of looking at it. But I suppose he would be young."

"Could you change him? Make him...not kill people?"

Erin looked up at Pisces, a glimmer of hope in her eyes. Ceria waited too. Pisces hesitated, but after a moment shook his head regretfully.

"I could stop him, perhaps. But it would be dangerous and all I would be able to do is render him harmless. Ceria is correct: I cannot give him a conscience. I do not know how. No one does."

"You have to stop him."

Yvlon said that. She stood up, staring at Pisces and Erin.

"If what you say is true, that skeleton is a huge threat. A thinking undead, one capable of leveling and leading others? It could become a threat capable of taking on Gold-ranked adventurers soon if not stopped."

"Yeah."

Erin's voice was quiet, but her eyes were suddenly focused. Her hands—she kept them on the table, but they trembled as she looked at Pisces.

"Can you stop him?"

"I can."

The [Necromancer] said it quietly. He looked at Ceria and she understood.

"Severing the link?"

"It's the easiest way."

Pisces explained to Erin and the others.

"Erin feeds Toren with her natural mana. No matter how far away she is, he and she are connected. Without her mana, he cannot survive, powerful

as he may be. If I cut it, he will cease to...live.”

Silence fell over the room. Yvlon opened her mouth, clearly wanting to tell Pisces to do it now, but she stopped when she saw Erin’s face. Ceria understood, a little bit. For all Erin yelled at her skeleton, Ceria had seen it with her since as long as she’d known Erin. It was Erin’s...

What? Friend was too strong a word. The girl had thought Toren was a mindless tool for the entire time. But she’d relied on him, even liked him. What he was to her couldn’t be explained in words.

And now she had to kill him.

“Perhaps we can track him down.”

That came from Ceria’s mouth. She blinked when she said it, but everyone stared at her and so she spoke, desperately trying to give Erin another option.

“If we set out, we might be able to track him down. You said he was at Esthelm? He may still be in the area. Or we could find him, look for rumors —”

“No. Do it now.”

Erin cut her friend off. She stared at Pisces. The mage stared back, looking as shocked as Ceria felt.

“Now?”

“Yes. Cut Toren’s supply of mana right now. This instant!”

“Are you sure?”

Why was Ksmvr saying that? But the Antinium had the same sense Ceria did. Erin was shuddering. Her face was pale and sweat stood out on her forehead. She was not well. But the look in her eyes was steel.

She spoke quietly to the others.

“He killed people. I asked, and I made sure. Toren killed people. Not just one, not just two, and not in self-defense. He killed them because... because he wanted to. And he’s going to keep killing people if he’s not stopped.”

She stopped, gulped. Erin closed her eyes, but then went on, voice hoarse, choking on her next words.

“If this were a movie...or a play...I’d be the stupid idiot who didn’t stop Toren before he killed thousands of people. He’s already killed dozens, maybe hundreds. And how strong would he become if he kept leveling up? Maybe if I knew I could find him I’d—but I can’t. He’s too far away. And I won’t let him kill anyone else. It has to be now.”

No one could answer her. It was the right decision. Pisces hesitated as Erin walked over to him.

“Do you need to cast a spell or something?”

“No. It’s a simple enough procedure. As the one who cast the spell I can unravel it. It will just take a minute—”

“Do it, then.”

Ceria stared at Pisces. He looked at her, uncertain. She just stared back. See, she wanted to ask him. See what you’ve done?

Pisces looked away. He made no sound, but after a moment laid his hands on Erin’s head. She shifted, once, and then was still.

No sound. No grand show of lights, no mystical chanting. Pisces just moved magic and Ceria saw a thread, thinner than silk and stronger than stone flowing from Erin out into the world. Pisces pulled at it and slowly, the connection broke.

That was it. It was over. He let go of Erin and she stared up at him.

“It’s done? He’s gone?”

“He will be. No undead can live without mana and Toren consumes... consumed more than most.”

“Okay.”

Erin took a few steps away from Pisces. She stared blankly at him, and then looked around the room. Everyone stared at her, Yvlon with a pale face, Ksmvr silently, Pisces full of what might have been regret, and Ceria with no idea what to say.

“I’m tired. I’m gonna go to sleep, okay?”

So saying, Erin began to walk up the stairs. She left the Horns of Hammerad behind and went into the small room that wasn’t hers and crawled onto the bed. She didn’t bother undressing, and lay down in the rough blanket. She put her pillow over her head, and curled up into the smallest ball possible.

She didn’t cry. She couldn’t cry. But something in her heart broke. Erin whispered the words into the night.

“Goodbye.”

She listened, hoping to hear a reply. But all she heard was silence.

3.25

That night, Erin had a nightmare.

It started, as nightmares sometimes do, happily. Erin was dreaming she was back in her inn, with Mrsha and Selys and even Lyonette. She was watching Ryoka put on a play of *Hamlet* and chasing Lyonette around with a sword, trying to kill her because she was a [Princess].

Generally speaking that would have given the dream away, but Erin was in the dream and only yelled at Lyonette to hurry and get stabbed so she could go offstage and get water. Mrsha was wiggling around in Erin's lap when she heard the knocking at the door.

Someone knocking? Even in her dream, the idea of someone coming to her inn was unexpected. And Erin didn't *want* to have a guest. She wanted to watch Lyonette duel Ryoka with poisoned swords! Bemused and half-annoyed, Erin stood up. She walked over to the door—or rather found herself there without moving her feet—and opened it.

A skeleton stood in the doorway. Toren. Erin opened her mouth to order him, but she stopped.

There was no flame in his eyes. No purple fire—or even the original blue fire of his eyes. Nothing.

She stared into empty sockets. Dead sockets. He was dead.

Erin took a step back. Behind her, the inn vanished. The people in it disappeared. And Toren stood in the doorway.

His eyes began to bleed. Red liquid trickled out of the gaping holes in his head. Erin looked around. She had to clean up the blood. But then she looked down and she saw she was holding a bloody blade in her hands.

“Out, darn spot.”

Only that wasn't the right line, was it? Was it damn spot? Erin stared down at her hands. Now she was on stage, only she was quoting from *Macbeth* instead of *Hamlet*! The crowd in the inn jeered at her and began to throw things. Miss Agnes stood to Erin's left.

“I told you we didn't have time to cook, dear. Look—they're running out of food to throw.”

Erin looked, and Toren was standing in front of her.

He was dead.

He reached out for her. Erin backed away, dropping the knife, her hands still crimson. The blood dripped to the ground and began a stream. A river. It washed her away and she reached out for help, but Toren was dead.

And she fell, fell as the blood washed her down and suddenly she was falling into Toren's eye socket. And the blackness was all around her and he reached for her—

Erin sat up with a gasp, sheets covered in sweat. It was still dark. She could hear movement downstairs—she realized she was in Agnes' inn at the same time she remembered to breathe. She was frightened, upset, still half-asleep. And deeply sad.

She'd killed him. Toren. A skeleton, yes, but her skeleton. Something... someone who could think.

Just like that. But she had to do it. She had to. He'd killed people. Erin just wished she could have stopped him, could have...

"Why didn't I realize it sooner?"

She put her head in her hands. She'd just thought he was a mindless thing, that was all. That his quirks were just...that. How could she have dreamed he'd ever learn to think? When she'd first met him, so long ago, he'd been so simple. But when she looked back, it all made sense.

He had learned to think. He'd found a soul, even if it was one that let him kill people. And she'd killed him. Just like that. In a second. With a few words.

And the worst part was, he might not be dead. Wouldn't it be just like a movie, or a book to have him come back? If he was still alive—

Somehow, Erin got up. She couldn't stay in bed, anyways. She had a job. Making food for her guests. She didn't want to do it, but that was the thing about jobs. You had to do them, and there was a bit of relief in having to do something right now.

"Hey, Erin. Good m—"

Ceria Springwalker froze with the greeting on her lips as Erin walked down the stairs. Erin pretended not to hear and moved slowly into the kitchen. Part of her felt bad, but—what would she say to Ceria? It wasn't a good morning at all.

Erin was in no mood to smile that day. She made food mechanically, but she had no desire to talk with anyone or deal with a crowd. And so the rest of the Horns of Hammerad, waking up to the smell of good food—noticed that the inn was oddly empty that morning.

Surprisingly so, given the popularity of last night and the quality of the food. It had to be Erin's new Skill, but no one dared suggest to the girl that she might be using it unconsciously. Even the supposed actual innkeeper, Miss Agnes, walked wide of Erin as she sat at a table with the others and picked at her plate.

"This is *your* fault."

Ceria told Pisces that over breakfast. He nodded, uncharacteristically humble.

"I regret the necessity of what occurred last night. But I must point out that Erin's decision was the most correct one she could have made."

"That doesn't change how she feels. She likes *Goblins*. How do you think she feels about killing her pet skeleton?"

No one answered the rhetorical question. Ceria drummed her fingers on the table and looked at Pisces sideways. She hesitated, then asked anyways.

"I'm not asking you to, but...*can* you make another one?"

Across the table, Yvlon sat up straight in her chair and looked hard at Ceria. She hadn't said a word to Pisces all morning, not even to greet him. Ceria ignored the look and stared at Pisces. He ran a hand through his hair, shrugging and then shaking his head.

"Theoretically? Of course. I did it once and I am a higher level than I was. But practically? The creation of Toren was a culmination of years of work. I had to do much...groundwork and the materials I used in his animation were exceedingly rare. Practically unique."

He looked at Ceria and then away. With a jolt she realized there could only be one thing he was referring to. He'd used *those*? On Toren?

Surely not all of them? It explained how Toren was able to regenerate. But how many had Pisces used? She opened her mouth to ask for more details and saw Yvlon staring at her. Ceria closed her mouth. Pisces went on.

"However, even if I did attempt to mimic my original design...I believe the product would not be something Miss Solstice desires. As you so adroitly pointed out, the theorems Cognita passed on to me were incomplete. True sentience is a byproduct of the spell matrices animating Golems and in this case, the undead."

Ceria nodded, although she saw Yvlon's eyes quickly glaze over. That's what happened when Pisces began to pontificate. Ksmvr was still listening intently, though.

“For all Cognita was Archmage Zelkyr’s greatest creation, even she admits her existence is an accident. The same goes for my creation of a new skeleton. Either the same issue will arise again, or I will create a truly mindless slave. Irregardless, it will not be Toren.”

“Yeah. I get it.”

Ceria nodded tiredly and looked at Erin. The girl was just staring down into her plate of bacon and rearranging them. Not into a face—she was stacking them up and then spearing as many bits as she could with her fork.

“We should do something for her.”

“I wish you the best of luck.”

Pisces nodded. Ceria turned to him, frowning.

“What’s that supposed to mean. If you think you’re going to run off while we—”

He raised his hands.

“Please, Springwalker. Credit me with some—well, that is part of the reason. But I believe you will agree with my reasoning when I explain myself.”

“Hurry up, then.”

Pisces nodded. He was clearly trying to make an effort to be sociable today.

“I would like to hire a horse—or perhaps wagon—and visit Albez to recover an artifact our expedition left behind.”

“What?”

The other Horns of Hammerad stared at him. Ceria frowned.

“What artifact? We couldn’t have possible left anyt—oh.”

Her eyes widened as she realized what Pisces was talking about. She glanced around as he nodded, keeping his face smooth and calm. No one was sitting close to them, for which Ceria was suddenly grateful.

“It slipped my mind as well, but I believe it would be an egregious waste to leave it there. With luck, any scavengers will have overlooked it if they even found our dig site.”

“True.”

Ceria nodded. She ignored Yvlon and Ksmvr’s confused looks as she pondered the issue.

“Yeah, going now would be best. We don’t have much coin—”

“We could borrow it.”

Dismayed, Ceria looked at Erin. But they had no choice, did they?

“Alright, I’ll ask Erin. Pisces, are you intending to go alone? Albez attracts monsters and more could have popped up by now.”

He raised his eyebrows.

“I am adept at using the [Invisibility] spell, you know.”

She hadn’t forgotten. Ceria frowned at Pisces.

“Monsters have noses. Some of them do, at any rate.”

Ksmvr raised his hand.

“I shall go with comrade Pisces. Although what is it that we are seeking?”

Pisces smiled knowingly.

“Simply recall our journey through the dungeon and you will come to the natural conclusion, Ksmvr.”

The Antinium paused. Yvlon looked at Ceria. The half-Elf just shrugged.

“Probably best if we don’t say it out loud. You never know.”

The woman frowned. Ceria looked at Erin and sighed.

“I’m going to stay with Erin. But if Ksmvr goes with you, Pisces, I’ll feel a lot better. Yvlon—”

“I’ll stay here.”

Yvlon said that almost too quickly. Ceria looked at her and nodded slowly.

“Then I’ll talk to Erin.”

The girl was staring at a fork loaded with greasy bacon when Ceria walked over.

“Hey, ah, Erin.”

“Mm?”

The girl didn’t look at her. Ceria coughed, looked around once, and then bent over to talk with her.

“I’m really, really embarrassed to ask this, but Pisces thinks there’s something else we could recover from Albez. Could you—”

Erin unhooked her money pouch from her belt and thrust it at Ceria.

“Grn.”

The half-Elf blinked at the pouch. She took it, extracted a few coins, and then gave the pouch back to Erin. She tossed the coins at Pisces who magically caught them in the air. He nodded to her and walked purposefully out of the inn with Ksmvr following. Ceria caught the Antinium asking Pisces again as they left.

“What is the artifact? I do not understand.”

Yvlon came over and smiled at Erin.

“Hey, Erin. How are you doing?”

“Blmblcrkn.”

It was probably a reply. Ceria stared at Erin, and then took the plate away from her. And the fork. It clearly wasn't helping matters.

“Why don't we go around the city? Come on.”

Ceria and Yvlon practically dragged Erin out of the inn, whereupon both did all they could to cheer Erin up. It worked, a bit. But the main reason Erin snapped out of her fugue was when the [Actors] came calling.

“Another huge success. I was on patrol and I was talking nonstop about the play last night. Barely got down the street before my shift was over.”

Wesle was talking excitedly with the others, stroking his non-existent mustache excitedly. Beside him, Jasi was all aglow with happiness, as she had been every day. Grev was already running about, his rucksack bulging with props, changes of costumes, and scripts.

Wesle and Jasi weren't the only two [Actors] of course. But they were certainly the stars. The other men and women—a surprising number being from the Watch—were all eager, expectantly waiting on Erin to help them learn another play in their spare time.

Faced with such enthusiasm, Erin couldn't help but respond in kind. They'd just finished learning *Hamlet*, and while they might perform that now and then, she had to get them working on another play.

She hesitated. In truth, Erin hadn't gone to that many plays over the course of her life. She now wished she'd seen musicals like *Wicked*, or at least watched it on YouTube. She knew *Phantom of the Opera* of course, but she didn't actually like that play so much. The Phantom was a jerk when you got down to it.

What else could she perform? *Macbeth*? Erin shuddered. No. Not that. And she didn't want to do Shakespeare at the moment for much the same reason.

Pygmalion? But it would be so hard to do the accents...Erin frowned. What about *A Doll's House*? But then...that was too modern, wasn't it?

“Drat.”

Ceria and Yvlon stood to the side of the inn, cleared out to give the [Actors] some room, talking intently. Excusing herself from the [Actors] who seemed only too happy to compare stories about the accolades they'd

received, Erin wandered over. Would they like to act? Ceria probably wouldn't, but then again...and Yvlon could probably play a great knight, right?

"I don't know what you're thinking of doing, but don't."

Erin paused as she got within earshot. Ceria was talking in a serious tone of voice, staring at the other adventurer. Yvlon looked...tense.

"He's a danger. You heard what he can do!"

"I know. And I've known how talented he is. He might be arrogant and stupid and thoughtless, but Pisces doesn't deserve to be killed just for creating one undead."

"And the people that thing killed? What if he makes another one?"

"If he does, I'll make sure he keeps it on a leash."

"How?"

Yvlon folded her arms and winced. Ceria scowled, not able to answer.

"The fact that he *hasn't* made another one tells you he's thought of the dangers as well."

"Or that he's waiting to gain enough levels to control them completely. And then what? Do we have a second Necromancer walking about?"

"I'm telling you, it won't come to that."

"I can't—"

The two women stopped when they realized Erin was standing next to them. Ceria turned, trying to smile. Yvlon didn't even bother trying.

"Erin. Um, is something wrong?"

"Don't kill Pisces just because he made Toren. Please."

Erin said that to Yvlon. The woman crossed her arms defensively, looking grim.

"I know he's your friend. But I can't just ignore what I've heard."

"Pisces isn't a bad person."

Yvlon stared at Erin incredulously. Ceria had a similar look on her face as well. Erin shook her head.

"He's not. I know he's really, really, *really* annoying, but he's actually sort of a good guy inside. He's saved my life at least twice. One time he froze a swarm of Acid Flies that were about to melt me, and the other—he sent a bunch of undead to protect me when Skinner attacked."

"Really? I didn't hear about that."

"I never told anyone. But I saw them—ghouls and zombies and skeletons. They helped protect me when the undead were attacking my inn."

Only Pisces could have sent them, but he never mentioned it.”

Yvlon hesitated, but she still looked unconvinced.

“Still—”

“You’re on his team. You can watch him better than if you scare him away.”

Ceria reminded Yvlon. The woman grimaced and sighed.

“Fine. He’s my teammate too, Ceria. Silver and steel, why can’t anything ever be simple? My brother never mentioned having trouble with his group, and one of them is a Dwarf.”

“A Dwarf? Really?”

Erin was fascinated. Yvlon nodded, smiling a bit.

“They’re rare enough on Terandria, never mind the other parts of the world. Ylawes said it was pure luck he ran into him in a tavern.”

“He’s your brother, right? He came all this way to look for you?”

That sounded like a great brother to Erin, who’d never had siblings. Yvlon grimaced, though. She spoke reluctantly.

“He’s...overprotective. And a far better adventurer than I.”

That was clearly all she wanted to say on the topic. After a second Yvlon changed the subject. She glanced behind Erin at the [Actors].

“I thought they came here to learn a new play.”

“They did. I just don’t know what I should teach them.”

Erin confessed to her friends. Ceria just shrugged. She liked the play she’d seen, but she couldn’t imagine practicing with the enthusiasm the others seemed to have.

“Let us know if we can help. I’m not going to memorize any lines, but I could always do a few spells if the performance needs more action.”

She flicked a few sparks of electricity from her fingers, making Yvlon swear. Ceria looked abashed—Erin saw the electricity trying to jump onto the metal on Yvlon’s arms.

“You can do that? Well of course!”

Erin slapped her forehead as she realized how stupid she’d been. Special effects! Any [Mage] could add so much to a performance! Especially someone like Ceria. At the very least, she could help cool down the inn when it was so full of people. Even on a winter night, so many bodies were stiflingly hot. But Ceria could probably lower the temperature enough to...

Erin's thoughts slowed down. She stared at Ceria. The half-Elf just blinked at her.

"Erin?"

She had lovely blonde hair. Well—in point of fact Ceria had dirty blonde hair. But Yvlon, now, she looked beautiful, and blonde as could be. Both women made Erin jealous—she didn't think she had a bad face or hair, but compared to Yvlon's beauty and Ceria's otherworldly appearance, she felt plain. And Ceria could use frost magic.

And it was winter...

"Erin? Are you okay?"

Winter plus frost magic equaled...what? It had to do with plays, and it was on the tip of her tongue! Erin screwed up her face as Ceria looked at her.

"Erin, do you need to sit—"

"Frozen!"

The word exploded out of Erin's mouth. Ceria blinked, wiped a bit of spit off her face, and stared at Yvlon. The other woman looked just as confused.

"You want Ceria to freeze the actors? The audience?"

"No, no!"

The young woman waved excitedly at the other two, mind suddenly ablaze with ideas. She looked at Ceria, and then began waving at the [Actors]. They were already congregating around her, sensing the impending drama.

"Hey you guys, come on over! I just had the greatest idea for the next performance we can do! It has singing!"

"Singing?"

Ceria raised her eyebrows, intrigued. She looked at Erin as the girl beamed at her.

"I like songs. Are there any good ones?"

There was no piano accompaniment. Pianos did exist in this world, but no one was going to lug one over to the Frenzied Hare. Instead, a few [Musicians] with string instruments provided a decent melody. That had been the hardest part.

The singing was not. On stage, Jasi, playing as the [Ice Queen] named Elsa sang a song so famous that it needed no introduction. Nor, it seemed, any plot. The play was over, but the song was being sung once more to a crowd who cheered as Jasi raised her hand to raise her castle of ice out of the wooden stage.

From behind the curtains backstage, Ceria cast weak frost spells, making snow and cold winds blow across the cheering audience. Concentrating hard, she made snow appear and fall over the fake little castle that they'd built. The snow melted almost instantly in the sweltering room, but the crowd didn't care. They cheered wildly as the song reached its thrilling conclusion.

Again. The [Mage] scowled at Yvlon and whispered to her as the song finished.

"This is the *third* encore performance!"

The other woman was sitting on a stool behind the stage, smiling as she ate tonight's meal, fish and chips, which was to say, fish and fried pieces of potato that Erin insisted were in some way 'french'.

"Bear with it. It's cheering Erin up."

Indeed, the other girl was clearly enjoying herself. Even though she was in the kitchen, Ceria could see her poking her head out every now and then to beam at the audience.

"Catchy song, though."

Ceria shrugged.

"It loses its charm fast, especially when you've got to do the effects."

"At least we're being paid."

"What's with 'we'?"

The half-Elf groused, but she had to smile. They were indeed being paid, and quite handsomely because the entire acting cast took a cut of the profits. And judging by the way the bag Grev carried around had to be emptied now and then, even a small cut would be a lot.

"You have to wonder though...where does Erin get all these stories from?"

Yvlon frowned as Jasi bowed and declined another performance. The audience called out in disappointment, but then rushed forwards to shake hands with the bowing [Actors] and buy them drinks.

Carefully, the half-Elf sat back on her haunches and didn't quite look at Yvlon.

“They come from her nation, I guess. She’s from far off.”

“Really? What continent?”

“Erin’s never said. I think it’s private. Ryoka’s from the same place, though.”

“Really? That makes sense.”

The two sat behind the curtains, looking through it at the room full of life and a different kind of magic. After a while, Ceria sighed.

“It really is better than adventuring, isn’t it?”

Yvlon nodded, seeing Wesle surrounded by admiring young women—and older women—and males, come to it, but mostly young women—and the other [Actors], just as adored. It was like how they’d been treated in Remendia, but somehow more intimate and even more reverential at the same time. The citizens had hailed the Horns of Hammerad as people, but these [Actors] had brought another world to life in front of the people here.

“No monsters to fight, good food if you’ve got the right inn...”

“Admiring crowds, if you like sweaty Humans. Lots of coin...”

The two sat in silence. After a while, Yvlon shook her head.

“Not for me.”

Ceria smiled.

“Me neither. I guess we’re doomed fools, aren’t we?”

The woman laughed.

“Maybe not if Pisces gets back with that invincible artifact of his.”

“Oh? You figured it out?”

“It wasn’t hard, and he’s right. It might be useful. Do you think he’ll be back tomorrow?”

“Early, hopefully. They’ll camp out in a safe place, or maybe just stay in Ocre. He says with a wagon driver who has a movement Skill they can be back very soon.”

“Good.”

The next day, Erin woke up feeling better. A lot better. She was still sad though, when she remembered why she should be. But she was better.

And now she knew what to do. She greeted Ceria and Yvlon cheerfully over breakfast—spiced porridge—and didn’t beat about the bush.

“It’s time to go back to Liscor.”

Yvlon only raised her eyebrows and Ceria smiled, but Miss Agnes, who'd joined them for breakfast, choked.

"What? But Miss Erin, surely you should wait. There are Goblins on the road and I don't know *what* we'll do without you. Why, there are all these fine [Actors] depending on you now..."

Sitting at a table next to theirs, Jasi, Wesle, and Grev looked up and gave Miss Agnes a flat look the woman failed to notice. It was their custom to eat together each day, especially since Jasi and Grev were staying at the inn.

"I really don't know what we'll do without you, Miss Erin. I'm sure we could tour other cities doing the plays you taught us. But I'd love to learn the rest..."

"I know. I know, and I'm sorry."

Erin smiled ruefully at Jasi and ruffled Grev's hair. He looked upset. But Erin's mind was made up.

"I need to go back. Liscor is my...home. Mrsha's there and she's all by herself. And Lyon's there too—I nearly forgot about her, but Selys say she's managing the inn. Somehow. But I need to get back before it falls apart or burns down or something."

The others had objections of course. Sensible ones, selfish ones...Erin ignored them all. She looked at Ceria and Yvlon.

"When Pisces and Ksmvr get back, how long until we can go?"

"Within the hour, if we get transport set up. We'll have to take a wagon, but we can get good horses and maybe even a driver."

Ceria nodded to Yvlon, already thinking of their route. The older woman nodded, biting her lip.

"Esthelm being retaken works for us. We can plan to stop there if we can avoid Goblin raiding parties. I'm not sure how safe it is—it's reportedly still a ruin, but better than camping by ourselves. And if we run into my brother's group..."

"You think we can get them to help us escort Erin?"

Yvlon nodded slowly.

"My brother will help anyone in need. The real problem might be afterwards. He'll try to take me north. But we'll cross that bridge if we get to it."

Ceria nodded silently. She didn't want to pry too much, but perhaps she should ask Yvlon why she didn't want to go home so badly. Erin thought of

what she had to do.

“I should say goodbye to Octavia.”

All things considered, Erin thought Octavia took the news well. There weren't even any tears. Or hugs. Or even a trace of sadness, really.

The dark-skinned [Alchemist] grinned happily and practically leapt off her stool in delight.

“You're going? Well, I won't say I'm not relieved—I've never met anyone so insane as you. When I count the times I nearly died—of course, I'm glad you came by before you left. I'd hate to have to charge interest on what you owe me when Ryoka gets back.”

“Hold on. What fees? Ryoka paid you already.”

Erin frowned at Octavia. The stitch-girl's dreadlocks swung as she shook her head condescendingly.

“That was for a few days. You've been here far longer—I'll admit she paid interest now and then, but if you factor in the number of discoveries you've made under my watchful supervision—not to mention hazard pay and having me participate in that play—”

“I'm gonna hit you.”

In the end, Erin didn't hit Octavia and the girl didn't get any more money, much to both girls' disappointment. But to her surprise, Octavia hugged Erin before she left.

“You take care, alright? If you ever need a potion, I'm sure Ryoka can run it down to Liscor for me. Who knows? We might meet again! And if we do, you're banned from ever mixing potions in my shop again.”

Erin laughed and hugged Octavia back. She'd miss her, she was surprised to realize. She'd miss Octavia's fast-talking ways. She'd miss the horrible smells in her shop—

She'd miss the entire city, if it came to that. Celum was...it wasn't as nice as Liscor, in some ways. It wasn't as exciting, and the people were just people. But it had its own charm, and it had taken Erin in when she was lost.

She'd miss it. But she had to go. So Erin went back to the Frenzied Hare and caught up with Ceria who'd found someone willing to make the relatively dangerous journey to Liscor, provided a Silver-rank team was

going with him. Yvlon had brought provisions for the journey and asked about the roads—no Goblin armies had been sighted close to any cities, although raiding groups had torched a few villages.

All they had to do was wait for Pisces and Ksmvr. And as it happened, the two were already close to the city. And they had the artifact in tow.

Earlier that day, Pisces had been willing to fight an entire Goblin army if it meant shutting Ksmvr up.

“What is the artifact? I still do not understand. Please enlighten me, comrade Pisces.”

It was the 38th time the Antinium had asked Pisces the question. Pisces knew that because he’d counted. Each time. They were sitting on a bumping wagon as it drove towards the Ruins of Albez. The mage blinked wearily as the dawn’s light hit his face.

It was far too early for this. But they had to move quickly, if they wanted to be back in Celum before evening. Ksmvr poked Pisces and the [Mage] snarled at him.

“Stop that!”

“I will if you answer my question. What is the artifact?”

“I told you to figure it out yourself!”

Part of Pisces dearly wanted to tell Ksmvr just to get it over with, but the young [Mage] was too stubborn for that.

“All the clues should be obvious. You were *there!* Just...think!”

“I have thought. I do not know what it could be. I wish for you to tell me.”

“Dead gods. It’s the *door*, the door. Okay!?”

That didn’t come from Pisces. It came from the wagon driver. She turned around, glaring, her eyes red and bloodshot. She was the same wagon driver who’d taken them from Remendia. She was the only one willing to risk her neck going so close to Albez, and clearly, she was unhappy with her decision.

Both [Mage] and Antinium stared at her. The wagon driver glared at them. After a moment, Pisces spoke.

“How did you come to that conclusion?”

“You explained it to the Ant about a half-dozen times. It was *obvious*. The door’s the only thing you lot didn’t take, apart from the ashes and the dungeon itself!”

The woman snapped at the two of them. Pisces turned to Ksmvr.

“You see?”

The Antinium only cocked his head sideways.

“Why is the door important? I do not understand. Please explain it to me, comrade Pisces.”

“First, call me comrade one more time and I will blast your mandibles *off* your face. Second—”

Pisces hesitated. But now that the secret was revealed, he had a deep urge to explain everything.

“The door is important because it cannot be destroyed. And it has a potent teleportation spell worked into its makeup.”

“Oh?”

Pisces nodded. He sat back in the wagon and stared up at the grey sky. It was far too cold, he felt, even with the warming spells that allowed him to wander around in nothing but his dirty robes. He gestured at Ksmvr to relax; the Antinium stayed sitting perfectly upright. Pisces made a face, but began to explain.

“Do consider it, dear Ksmvr. In our haste to acquire our spoils and flee the area, we had neglected to consider the magnitude of enchantment that must have been laid on this door. Not only did it survive a magical fire that damaged every artifact it touched—but it actually destroyed part of the fire construct when we used it as an impromptu weapon.”

“Ah yes. It was quite useful.”

“And yet, we, in our rush to escape, completely neglected to remember it. A vast oversight. Then again, I do not believe we could have carried it away as exhausted as we were. Fortuitously, my adept memory seized upon our neglect and led me to—”

“Yeah, yeah. Shut up and go get it already, would you?”

The wagon jerked to a halt, making Pisces bite his tongue. He glared at the woman driving the wagon, but she just stared back.

“Hurry up. If you want to be back in Celum, get moving. I’m not waiting around in this place forever. Even if it’s winter, monsters could still be about.”

That was true, and so Pisces and Ksmvr cautiously descended into Albez. They were quite willing to retreat at the first sight of any monsters, door or no door, but it seemed the ruins were still quite deserted.

“Let us go then, Ksmvr. Your strength should be invaluable in carrying the door.”

“Yes, Pisces. I shall lead the way in case monsters have retaken the dungeon.”

“Good point. I’ll stay...this far behind you. Lead on!”

There were no monsters, although there was a good deal of ash. Pisces and Ksmvr found the door lying in a pile of it. The [Mage] sneezed when Ksmvr pulled the door out. The Antinium nodded as he lifted it upright with all three of his arms.

“I can carry my end of it quite easily. If you will assist me—”

“Not so fast. We must descend into the pit.”

The Antinium paused and turned to Pisces in surprise.

“Why?”

Pisces nodded at the door.

“The door is only half of the spell. The other half, if you recall, teleports us to a set location. Into the pit in this case. A small object—usually a stone, perhaps some other mundane object—acts as the anchor for the teleportation spell. We must recover it or I’ll be teleported here if I should make a mistake with the door.”

“But is it not extremely dangerous? Captain Ceria covered the [Insanity] spell with mud, but it may have been removed in the time since we were gone.”

Pisces smiled confidently.

“Have no fear, Ksmvr. I am well-prepared for this eventuality.”

As it turned out, his solution was much the same as Ceria’s. After Pisces built a staircase out of bone, he cast a spell which filled the pit with billowing yellow smoke. Coughing and swearing, the mage descended into the pit and shot clinging mud in every direction. After he’d released the spell and Ksmvr had come down, the Antinium saw the pit was covered, with no sign of the [Insanity] symbols on the walls.

“That was quite admirable, Pisces.”

He complimented the wheezing mage. Pisces coughed, and waved a hand.

“Think nothing of it. This is a simple trap to bypass, if the correct precautions are taken.”

Ksmvr nodded at the plain truth of that statement. He looked around.

“And where is this anchoring stone?”

“It shouldn’t be too big. It could even be the size of my hand—smaller. I can find it ah...if I trace the magic link...here!”

Pisces frowned and then pointed to a spot directly in the center of the pit. It turned out what he was looking for was a round stone small enough to fit into his palm, embedded into the stone bottom of the pit. This proved to be very difficult to extract. Ksmvr still had the Goblin’s enchanted short sword, but even with all his strength he could barely chip at the stone floor of the pit.

“Of course it *is* designed to be a trap.”

Pisces groused as he began blasting the area around the stone with flames. Both he and Ksmvr knew that stone when heated was far more vulnerable to cracking. After about ten minutes of sustained fire blasting the ground, it was weakened enough for Ksmvr’s blade to crack the stone.

“It is very hot, Pisces.”

So saying, Ksmvr handed the magical stone—which showed no damage despite the heat—to Pisces. The [Mage] swore and dropped it the moment he touched the black rock.

“It’s *burning!*”

“That is what I said.”

“Then don’t—allow me to choose a far more sensible solution.”

The wagon driver, whose name was Adelynn, although no one had bothered to ask it, was dozing in her driver’s seat when her horses took fright. She looked up and blanched as she saw the six skeletons carrying the enchanted door and anchoring stone over their heads. Pisces and Ksmvr sat on the door like a seat. They waved at the wagon driver. Only when they got close did she throw a bit of snow at them.

“Call your damn undead away, [Necromancer]! You’ll spook my horses! I swear, if they wrench an ankle you’ll all walk home!”

“Calm down, good Mis—”

A bit of snow hit Pisces in the face.

“Get them away, I said!”

A few minutes later, the cart rumbled back towards the road and Celum, bereft of any skeletons. But it did have one new passenger: the door lay

between Pisces and Ksmvr as the [Mage] pored over it and Ksmvr stared at the small stone in his hands. To the Antinium the rock appeared totally ordinary, which he supposed was the point.

“Now that we have the door, what do you propose we do with it, Pisces?”

“That my friend...is a very good question. I have no idea.”

Pisces looked up for a moment before he went back to staring at the door. Ksmvr noticed the mage's eyes unfocused as he stared at what the Antinium could only assume was the magic enchantment making up the door. Pisces seemed to be tracing the spell while simultaneously attempting to avoid triggering the door's automatic teleportation effect.

Every now and then he failed, and would appear on Ksmvr's lap. The Antinium watched as this happened now. Pisces yelped, popped out of existence on his side of the wagon, and appeared a little bit above Ksmvr. In the ensuing tangle, Pisces fought his way clear.

“Dead gods—*give me that!*”

He snatched the stone back from the Antinium and placed it on his side of the wagon. A bit of snow flew from the front and hit him on the head.

“Stop doing that! You're scaring the horses!”

“Shall I reanimate them for you? I'm sure undead horses would be a lot faster than these slow nags.”

Pisces smiled nastily. His reply came in another bit of snow which struck him on the shoulder. Grumbling, Pisces went back to the door.

After a few moments, Ksmvr nodded and spoke up.

“We could make a shield out of it. I could hold it up with comrade Yvlon when fighting spellcasters.”

The young man's head rose and he stared at Ksmvr.

“Really? That's your idea?”

Ksmvr nodded, appreciating Pisces' enthusiasm.

“A shield seems to be the most appropriate use of the door. We could make a harness so Comrade Yvlon could use it in place of her armor. It would protect her back so she would have no need of armor. If an enemy attacked all she would have to do would be to turn around.”

The Antinium paused, waiting for feedback. Pisces just stared at him. After a moment, he cleared his throat.

“I should like to see that. But I believe using the door as any form of personal armament should be employed only as a matter of last resort. Even

if you were to block a spell with this door, [Fireball], for instance, the explosion would still affect those hiding behind the door. Any neophyte mage could easily burn you with a low-Tier flame spell were you to use it as cover.”

“Oh. I see.”

Ksmvr felt disappointed. Seeing this, Pisces felt moved to offer him a bone.

“The true value in the door might not be in its practical use at all, but rather as a tool of study for me. I can learn a lot from the enchantments woven into it.”

The Antinium perked up. What helped Pisces was a boon for The Horns of Hammerad.

“Really? Can you copy the spells on the door?”

“Copy?”

Pisces coughed, and then laughed. He shook his head.

“That is far beyond my capabilities.”

“Why? Is it not simply a matter of reproducing the spell? That should be doable with time, should it not?”

“Yeah, [Mage]. What’s wrong? Is it too complex for you?”

Pisces ignored that comment from the front. Sniffing archly, he sat back. He took on the tone Ksmvr had associated with a lecture as he spoke out loud.

“The issue, Ksmvr, is that the nature of magic is not so linear as the philistines might have you think.”

“Hah!”

Again, Pisces ignored the wagon driver’s comment. Ksmvr nodded at him encouragingly. Magic was fascinating to him.

“Indeed?”

“Oh yes. You see, if this door—or should I say, this impressively enchanted self-activating portal device—were simply one enchantment, I dare say even Springwalker would be able to ascertain its nature quite quickly. But it is clearly not one enchantment. And the true exponential difficulty of a spell occurs when multiple layers exist.”

Ksmvr considered Pisces’ explanation and nodded.

“I see. So multiple spells cast on the same object increase the difficulty of analyzing and copying it?”

Pisces deflated somewhat at the Antinium’s calm response.

“...Yes.”

He turned back to the door, frowning at it.

“If it were just something like reinforcement, well, I could do that to a piece of wood, although not with the finesse or force of a true [Enchanter]. They could turn a piece of parchment into something as strong as steel...but as I’ve said magic *changes* when you layer another spell on top. It truly is quite incredible how many spells are worked into this wood.”

“That is why mages study so continuously?”

“To master the nuance of each spell and understand how magic can change, broadly speaking, yes. Even memorizing spells takes time, and comprehending concepts like spatial travel, well...”

“Can you [Teleport]?”

Pisces ignored that question. He gestured grandly at the door sitting on the back of the wagon.

“This wonder of magical engineering is clearly the work of a master [Mage]. Perhaps even an [Archmage]? Ah, probably not.”

He coughed.

“But studying it will surely raise my level, and it will be a far greater challenge than simply reading from a book of spells. When Springwalker sees this...”

“So you cannot copy the spell?”

Pisces paused, but then he nodded with a rueful smile.

“I wouldn’t even dare try. The spells are so tangled up that reproduction is impossible. I’d have to unravel each layer of spells and if that didn’t destroy the entire weaving...no, no, I only intend to study what parts are visible.”

He sighed, losing some of his posturing. Ksmvr nodded.

“I see. Are there some parts which are easier?”

Pisces shrugged, irritated by his moment of genuine expression. He scowled as he bent back over the door, poking at the brass handle.

“The entire thing is a mess. Let me concentrate. It’s hard enough to sit on this bumpy wagon—”

“Watch it, [Mage].”

The wagon driver snapped back at Pisces. He made a face. Ksmvr sat forwards too. The door was just plain, solid wood of course, but now he was very invested in Pisces’ discoveries.

“Surely there are some aspects which are simplest to understand. The triggering mechanism for the spell was analyzing it, was it not?”

“Relatively simple, yes. Of course the part of the spell that detects people investigating it is fiendishly complex. But the trigger component I identified straight off.”

Pisces dismissed that with a wave of the hand. Ksmvr nodded eagerly.

“In that case, would it not be easiest to focus on that part of the spell, knowing the method to activation and outcome?”

In his multi-faceted eyes, the Antinium saw the young man pause. Pisces stared at Ksmvr, and then down at the door. He cleared his throat.

“Uh. Yes. That would be...well, it’s a good place to start as any, I suppose.”

“It is a shame you cannot reverse the effect. That would have been very convenient in the pit.”

Ksmvr meant this only as a segue into asking whether Pisces could teleport him a few times, just so Ksmvr could see what it was like when he wasn’t about to die. But Pisces’ face froze and after a second he burst into a huge and uncharacteristic grin.

Somewhat unnerved, Ksmvr paused as Pisces turned to him. The [Mage] gingerly clapped a hand on Ksmvr’s shoulder. The Antinium stared at the hand. After a moment Pisces let go.

“You, Ksmvr, are clearly a natural-born scholar, as perhaps befits your advanced standing among the Antinium.”

“Thank you.”

“Reversing the spell. What a novel idea! And of course the actual binding spell on the stone is ludicrously simple compared to the door. Why, it wouldn’t be hard to reverse—that is to say, to create a trigger to activate the teleportation spell and bring whomever was there to the door! In fact...”

“Does this mean you can teleport me?”

“More than that, my dear Ksmvr. If this means what I think it does—here...you hold this and I shall...”

The Antinium and Human excitedly rocked back and forth on the wagon, jabbering on about ‘possible sequential instances of anchorage’ and ‘activation mechanisms’ and so on. At the head of the wagon, Adelynn tried not to listen. After a while, she tried to plug her ears with both fingers, but it was hard to do that and guide the wagon. She sighed.

“You’re late.”

Ceria scowled at Pisces as he and Ksmvr lugged the door over to the front of the Frenzied Hare. The two had attracted quite a lot of attention as they’d dragged and carried it down the street. Now Ksmvr laid the door against the wall of the inn as Pisces panted for breath.

“Don’t blame me. If I could have conjured a few undead we wouldn’t have taken so long! Why no one appreciates the untapped potential of such labor—”

“Yes, yes.”

Ceria sighed, but she stared at the door, mildly impressed Pisces had managed to support his end of it. It was as heavy as it looked, she knew, and it looked *heavy*.

“Is that the door? The magic door?”

Erin stared dubiously at the heavy wood door. It looked as plain as plain could be. She wondered if Pisces and Ceria were playing a prank on everyone else, but Yvlon nodded.

“That’s the door. It doesn’t look like much but—if you could make armor out of it I’d wear it. I saw it take damage that would have shredded my plate armor.”

“Wow.”

No matter how hard Erin stared at it, she just couldn’t see it. But Pisces was clearly excited by the door. He waved his hands at Ceria, talking quickly.

“You won’t believe what I—and Ksmvr I suppose—have discovered! It’s a revolutionary—nay, unprecedented loophole in the spell matrix! I can’t believe it wasn’t covered!”

“Oh yeah? What’s so incredible?”

Ceria looked skeptical. Pisces pointed to the door, grinning broadly, one of the few times Erin had ever seen him happy.

“I managed to isolate the location aspect of the spell. Not only that—I figured out how to trigger it independently of the detection trap.”

Erin’s head swiveled with Yvlon’s towards Ceria. The half-Elf gasped.

“You don’t mean—seriously? And you did it on the ride *back*? Impossible!”

“Not.”

Pisces was smug. He gestured to the door.

“It all came down to a loophole. If you look around the doorknob—perhaps they didn’t have an adept mastery of enchantments? Or maybe the handle was added too late—either way I forced my way into the bindings from there and...”

He began talking gibberish, or perhaps Erin’s ears just shut down. She gathered that something important had happened by the way Ceria was reacting, but she couldn’t figure out what.

“Are we going to go?”

They had the wagon all ready, and a somewhat surly wagon driver ready to take them to Liscor. Ceria had said they’d be leaving soon. Yvlon shrugged, looking resigned.

“Mages. Give them a minute and then we’ll interrupt.”

Erin nodded. She looked around and frowned.

“Hey, where’s Ksmvr?”

The Antinium was nowhere to be seen. He hadn’t gone inside—had he run off? Erin wanted to ask Pisces—she didn’t want to go have to find Ksmvr as well!—when she heard a *pop*. Ksmvr appeared in front of the door, holding a small stone in his hands.

Yvlon gasped. Erin jumped and people on the street shouted in surprise. Ksmvr looked around proudly and Pisces broke off from chattering with Ceria to point at him gleefully.

“There, you see?”

“You can *teleport* to the door?”

“Yes!”

In an instant Erin was next to Ksmvr. She stared down at the stone in his hands and then at Pisces.

“How? Where? What?”

“It’s very simple. Actually, it’s not, but I’ll give you a simple explanation. The long and short of it is that we can take advantage of the door’s teleportation spell to teleport to the anchoring stone connected to it—or vice versa.”

Erin pointed at the stone in Ksmvr’s hands.

“You can teleport to that? And teleport back?”

“That’s what I said.”

“How many times?”

Yvlon's eyes were wide with amazement. Pisces stroked at his chin, shrugging, speaking out loud.

"Any number of times. In time of course the enchantment will lose magic—it requires a huge amount to activate. But here's the wonderful part—the magic will replenish itself over time!"

"Really?"

Erin was so excited her heart was beating out of her chest. Pisces nodded proudly.

"Quite extraordinary, really. It absorbs the natural mana in the environment—like any acceptably constructed artifact, I suppose—but it allows for practically unlimited uses of the teleportation magic!"

"This is incredible. That changes everything. This thing is—it's actually *useful*."

Ceria murmured as Ksmvr tried to keep people from crowding around the door. She tapped at the wood.

"How much could we sell it for? If you think of it as—as a way to travel, you could get from one end of the city to the other in seconds! Any [Lord] would want it, if only as a novelty."

"A bit plain for a [Lord]'s door."

Yvlon put that in, although she looked no less impressed. She ran a hand over the wood surface.

"But paint it and—could we get a hundred gold coins for it, do you suppose?"

"Hundreds? Try thousands. As I was saying, this is incredible! But we need not sell it yet—just imagine the utility of it in a dungeon! We could retreat at any time."

Pisces was talking faster as he waved his arms about. Ksmvr was proudly showing the stone to people and resisting all attempts of people trying to take it from him. Erin stared down at the door, and an idea seized in her mind. She looked up and spoke loudly.

"I want it."

Everyone stopped talking. The Horns of Hammerad stared at her. Erin stared back. She pointed at the door.

"I want it. Can I have it?"

"What?"

Pisces was the first to speak. He looked incredulous.

“This door is—as much of a treasure as anything we recovered from Albez. It’s far more useful than a bag of holding. And you want—”

“Yes. I want it.”

Erin didn’t say out loud that the Horns of Hammerad owed her, but they had promised, hadn’t they? They’d said a treasure, and she could think of nothing she would want more than this door. She saw Ceria exchange a glance with the others. Pisces was spluttering.

“You can’t just demand—this is far too sudden to—”

“Yes.”

Ceria nodded. She smiled at Erin, and looked at the door.

“For you, Erin? Yes, you can have this...door.”

Yvlon nodded as well.

“We wouldn’t have gotten anywhere if it weren’t for you. And you lent us your gold—twice, now. Of course you can have it.”

Ksmvr nodded as well.

“This seems to be an acceptable form of remuneration. Here is your teleportation stone.”

He handed it to Erin. She held it gingerly. Pisces kept spluttering.

“But—I just got—it was *my* discovery and—”

“And you did well. Thank you.”

Erin smiled widely at Pisces. He blinked at her and threw his hands up in exasperation.

“Fine. I am outnumbered and overruled by the imposition of what some might call honor or common decency. Take the damned door!”

“I will.”

The young woman patted the door.

“My door.”

Pisces sniffed, clearly upset. Ceria laughed, and slung an arm around his shoulder. He froze up for a second and stared at her. She seemed surprised by the action as well, and released him quickly.

“Cheer up. Erin made a lot of food—and lunch for you two since you missed it. Although I suppose it would be dinner, now.”

Instantly he brightened up.

“Ah, well, I suppose that—”

“—But you’ll have to eat it on the wagon. We’ve got to go now if we want to get to any sort of settlement by nightfall.”

Ceria dragged Pisces back as he headed towards the inn. He complained, but soon he was helping drag the door onto the back of the wagon. Erin turned to help push it further in, and stopped.

A group of people were standing behind her. Miss Agnes, Maran, Safry, Jasi, Grev, Wesle, the [Actors], a number of regular patrons from her inn, Octavia...they stood, smiling at her.

Slowly, Erin stepped towards them. She felt...quite empty inside, really. As if there weren't any tears to cry. And there weren't.

There was only a smile. She smiled at them, and went to each one, hugging and kissing Wesle on the cheek and Grev on a dirty forehead, talking and saying goodbye.

But not forever. And so the emptiness in her filled, and when the wagon started to move, Erin could shed a tear. But not a sad tear. She was just so full of memories and happiness that a bit came out anyways.

She sat on the wagon as it rolled out of the city. The Horns of Hammerad sat around her. Friends. Yvlon and Ceria talked animatedly about the play they'd been a part of, recounting the good bits to Ksmvr while Pisces devoured the packed lunch Erin had made for him and Ksmvr.

Erin sat back, and as the cold evening breeze blew past her face, she smiled. A bit sadly.

It was time to go. Celum was...a lovely place. But it wasn't home. She had to go back to Liscor.

"Goodbye."

She whispered it to the wind. Not sadly—in her heart she promised to return some day. There was more to this world besides Liscor. And some day she would explore it.

Some day. But for now she was going back. To Mrsha and Selys and even annoying Lyonette. She wanted to go back so desperately it hurt Erin's chest. But she wouldn't forget what she'd experienced here.

They rolled out of the city and Erin finally left Celum behind.

It was a quiet wagon that slowly rode down the trampled road, slowly moving south. The wagon driver didn't have a movement Skill, but he was used to the uncertain road and he was skilled and Skilled enough to detect

danger. It would take a day – or two or even three – to get to Liscor, but they'd get there, and hopefully without running into any danger.

Erin sat next to the other Horns of Hammerad, not saying anything. At first she'd chatted, but the cold and wind had a way of silencing even the most spirited conversation. And she felt a bit selfish, but she wished—she wished she was back in the Frenzied Hare right now rather than moving around in the cold winter.

If she ever got home, Erin would never complain about an airplane again. That was what she decided.

“Anyone want dinner?”

“It's cold.”

Pisces grumbled as he lay sprawled out on the wagon. Ceria, sitting next to his foot, shifted it aside irritably.

“I could warm it up with magic. So could you.”

“I would much rather have stayed the night in the inn in the city. If we had left the next day—”

“If we had, we'd be that much behind. I want to get moving while the roads are clear.”

Ceria pointed that out acerbically. But from the way she glanced back at Celum, still visible in the distance, Erin knew she felt the same.

“After all my hard work with the door, I am resigned to this. A cold meal on wagon back. Truly, gratitude is a foreign concept among even the staunchest of comrades.”

Pisces sat up, grumbling. Erin wanted to grumble back at him, but she was grateful for the door, really. He really was a genius, just like Ceria sometimes said. So she'd let him grumble a bit more.

“What are you going to do with the door, Erin?”

Yvlon asked that, wrapped up in her coat. Erin had to think.

“I'll probably put the door somewhere in the city! It'll be so cool! I can pop in and visit Selys all the time, and I'll get so many visitors since it'll be easy to get to my inn!”

“Not to mention it'll be safer since you can get away if there's a monster attack.”

The woman nodded approvingly. Pisces just sniffed.

“What a waste.”

“What would you do with it, then?”

“Certainly not use it to for a simple walk of a few minutes. Why, with a door so useful I’d link it to a safe space—perhaps far underground. Or perhaps as a trap to deter unwelcome visitors. I could fix it so that at your command anyone unsavory was transported deep underground—”

“You can send people that far?”

Erin was surprised. All the Horns of Hammerad nodded, looking grim. Ceria kicked the door and cursed as she winced in pain.

“The door teleported us to a pit trap when we first found it. And like Pisces said, it recovers magic. So it won’t run out. It’s a great tool for you, Erin. I’m glad we can give it to you.”

Erin nodded, but her heart had suddenly jolted in her chest. She took a breath, trying to contain the excitement trying to explode out of her body in case she was wrong.

“Well, if this door is so powerful, it can probably teleport people a long way away, right?”

“Any [Teleport] spell can do that.”

Pisces murmured as he tried to get himself comfortable in his spot in the wagon. He pointed at Erin.

“You were there when that objectionable Gazi teleported away, were you not? Her spell took her far away. Across the ocean, I’ll wager. Thousands of miles. True, that was with a customized spell for long-distance, but a normal [Teleportation] spell can still cover many miles, albeit at increased mana cost.”

“So this door—”

“—Is clearly a relic of a past pinnacle of magical achievement. Indeed, that entire room—the private hidden store room of a powerful mage—was filled with wonders. Putting aside the mediocre traps preceding the door, the pit trap was truly a death sentence even for a Named Adventurer. If all the [Insanity] runes had been active, I cannot imagine any Skill or spell short of...Tier 7 that would have saved you from an untimely end.”

“Wow.”

Erin shivered a bit, realizing how dangerous it had been. But she pressed forwards anyways.

“So this door is incredible because it can teleport people really far. And it recovers magic. So...”

“So what?”

Ceria looked at Erin blankly. The girl paused, and then pointed to the stone in Ksmvr's hand.

"Why didn't we just leave that in Celum? If we made another door or something, couldn't we travel back and forth to the wagon? And once it gets to Liscor, I mean, I don't know if it's too far, but could I use it as a door to..."

Her voice trailed off. Everyone on the wagon—including the wagon driver—was staring at Erin with an open mouth. Pisces closed his.

"Remarkable. And of course it would work. The charge might not last for more than one or two mass teleportations per day but if you found a way to recover mana—"

"Ksmvr!"

Ksmvr shot to his feet.

"I will go to the city."

"Hold on! Let me tune the stone. I had it so you would teleport with it. But clearly we need to...hm..."

Pisces and Ceria clustered around the stone, arguing with each other as Yvlon, Ksmvr, and Erin watched with bated breath. In a few moments Ksmvr was jumping off the wagon and running quite quickly back towards the city in the distance.

The others settled back in the wagon to wait. They didn't speak much—just watched Ksmvr's shape slowly disappear. The minutes felt like hours, and after an interminable number of them had passed, Yvlon coughed.

"Been a while. Ksmvr should have made it to the city by now. Do you think it didn't—"

Pop. Ksmvr appeared back on the wagon. Everyone shouted, but he raised his hands.

"The stone is at the Frenzied Hare. I have explained to Miss Agnes but she does not quite understand. Shall we attempt to return now?"

"Yes. All we have to do is—"

From his seat on the wagon, the driver half-turned to look. He caught only a glimpse of the five people clustered around the door lying on his wagon when he heard a quiet *pop* of air and they vanished.

The horses, pulling the wagon, snorted in surprise when they felt the sudden change in weight. For his part, the wagon driver stared at the spot in dismay.

What was he supposed to do? Keep driving? While these adventurers feasted in the inn? That wasn't fair!

But it was what he was paid for, so after a moment the wagon driver urged his horses on, scowling. He drew his scarf tightly around his face as the night grew closer around him.

The poor wagon driver sat miserably hunched over in the cart as the horses plodded onwards through the cold night. After a few moments, the door opened on the wagon. The wagon driver gaped as from out of the wagon a girl stepped out with a sudden outpouring of noise—and heat!

She stepped *up*, since the door was lying on its back, but somehow was facing the right way when she stood upright on the wagon.

“Woog. That’s trippy.”

She muttered as she held something in her hands. The wagon driver stared at her. The girl—was her name Erin?—smiled at him. She held out what was in her hands. The man looked and saw a steaming bowl of soup.

“It’s fresh! Sorry about the wait—Pisces said he could actually make the door connect! Don’t ask me how—he put the stone, you know, the anchor-thingy? He put it in another door and he and Ceria did some magic to it and look! Portal door!”

The man just stared at her. Slowly, he took the bowl of soup. It did indeed smell fresh, and the hot liquid warmed his cold hands and soul in the winter night.

“I’m making popcorn as well. I’ll bring you some when I’m done! Do you want something to drink with that?”

The man brightened up. The girl opened the door, stepped *down* and into the inn and the door closed. After a few more minutes, the door opened and popcorn was handed over in a bowl along with a big mug of ale. The man stared down at the white, fluffy kernels seasoned with butter, salt, and yeast—which was the only way to eat popcorn, or so Erin claimed. He tried some, and cheered up even more.

And so the wagon plodded onwards, bearing its curious load. It traveled down the silent, winter roads, slowly heading south. To a city claimed by Drakes, Gnolls, and the strange Antinium. To Liscor. To a place known as The Wandering Inn.

To home.

Author's Note:

It took me a long time to get Volume 3 out as an e-book. And only Part 1 at that! Well, I do apologize for the delay. In truth...I'm better at writing new chapters than I am at revising, fixing typos, and releasing the old volumes, especially as it's all online. But some people have told me they really like to read via e-book and this does allow the audiobooks to be made, so I apologize for the delay!

It really is odd to think that Volume 2 came out as an e-book in 2019, and now we're up to Volume 7 and closing in on the ending of that! Each Author's Note is a snapshot of where I am. At that time, we'd passed 4 million words and in Volume 6.

I think we're definitely past 6 million now. And the story is continuing and you're all reading! Again—Part 1 and I promise not to make you wait a year before Part 2 of Volume 3! But it is strange, looking back on it. There was a time when Erin was trapped in Celum. And *now*, well, if you look at where Volume 7 is—

Spoilers, spoilers. But there is so much more to read! And apparently, people still enjoy 4.5 more Volumes worth of words! I hope you will too, sincerely, if you've read all the way here. The best is yet to come is an odd thing to promise after a million words of *The Wandering Inn*...but you have at least four million more to go, if my math is right. Maybe five. What are numbers?

I hope that makes you happy, rather than anything else. Thank you for reading,

--pirateaba

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P I R A T E A B A

the WANDERING INN



BOOK 6

THE GENERAL
OF IZRIL

The General of Izril

The Wandering Inn, Book 6

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Goblins.

Goblins?

Goblins! Goblins, Goblins, *Goblins!*

Goblins.

Goblins.

The word was on everyone's lips. From the Walled Cities to the Antinium Hives, from the tribal Gnoll camps to the Human cities like Invrissil, the news had flown on the warming winds. Goblins were back.

And this time there was a Goblin Lord.

For some, the news was just the conversation of the day. Those who were hundreds or thousands of miles away took comfort in their distance. So long as this Goblin Lord was dealt with swiftly, there would be no problem for *them*. Now, a Goblin King? That would be disastrous, which is why the leadership or command or someone in charge was doing something about the Goblin Lord.

Right?

People closer to the Goblin issue were less sanguine about the entire affair. They demanded, sometimes loudly, that something be done. Because the Goblins were a menace, a threat, a pest that had to be wiped out every few years. Only, unlike plagues of cockroaches, rats, mites, or other vermin, Goblins were a lot more dangerous. And they became something truly frightening given half a chance.

No one gave them that chance. Armies were being raised. Humans, Drakes, and a few Gnoll tribes began making preparations to end the threat before it had fully begun. The Goblin Lord had crushed two Drake armies; so four would be sent this time. Or six. Or eight. The Humans were already fielding huge forces of their own for the Goblin Lord if he marched north.

In no one's mind was the idea of negotiating with the Goblins, or making peace. Or defeat. Goblins would do damage, but they would die. They would always die, and it was just a matter of the cost. Everyone knew that.

Strangely, so did the Goblins. In all the commotion about their species, few people gave thought to what the Goblins were actually thinking. Oh, there was all sorts of speculation and prediction about what the Goblin Lord might do, but what he as a thinking individual thought? None.

But in three parts of Izril, so late into the night that it was becoming day, three Goblins looked up. They all had a sense. A premonition.

Because, after all, they were all of the same species. Their fates were intertwined.

The first was the Goblin Lord. He looked up as his armies marched past the city of Liscor. Around him, his Goblins cheered and whooped, sending arrows towards the walls until one of his lieutenants ordered them to stop wasting ammunition.

Silent watchers on the walls watched as the Goblins passed, not returning fire. They might have against a lesser host, but none dared provoke the flood of Goblins in black armor. The Goblin Lord's army was tens of thousands strong and they marched across the plains. Northwards.

The Goblin Lord turned his head, seeing almost perfectly in the darkness. Liscor's walls rose to his left. He sneered at them, at the Drakes hiding behind stone. But he did not order his army towards the walls. He had orders.

There was a structure on one of the hills closest to the city. An inn, a very odd one with some kind of tower. The Goblins shot flaming arrows at it, grumbling when the arrows failed to set the building aflame. Indeed, some of the arrows bounced *off* the glass windows, which was rather unusual. But it was too close to the city to loot, and was probably empty anyways.

So the army marched on, northwards. The Goblin Lord sighed. He could sense them. His people. Goblins. He was coming to claim them, by blood if necessary. And if they refused to kneel? He would have their bodies at least.

And they knew it.

Garen Redfang stalked the halls of Tremborag's mountain, sword in hand. A few of the Goblins from his tribe followed, the ones who hadn't joined Rags. They hung back as Garen walked forwards, his red blade at the ready.

Ahead of him, Goblins got out of the way. Hobs, regular Goblins—when he had first arrived, they had treated him like any ordinary Hob or an inferior outsider. Several fatal duels had established his rank.

Garen was angry. He was always angry. He hated sitting in the mountain, hated that Rags had left, and hated Tremborag. He and the Great

Chieftain did not get along. But he acknowledged Tremborag's might. And it was might they needed.

So the leader of the Redfang tribe walked. He could *feel* the Goblin Lord coming. Tremborag could too, which is probably why he was eating alone, roaring for females and wine. The fat Goblin had to know.

An end was coming. For Goblins. A crossroads. And though the Goblin Lord was meant to unify the tribes, Garen would never kneel to him. Never. So the Hobgoblin walked, restless. Waiting for the scent of blood on the warming winds. Waiting for war.

And the last Goblin to look up and sense something on the wind was Rags. The small Goblin was listening to some of her Goblins having a farting competition and grimaced as Pyrite took the lead in a noisy—and smelly—way. She pulled her blankets over her head and growled to herself.

She couldn't have said why she was restless. If she had to put words to it, it was probably the very smelly odors drifting on the wind towards her. In the end she sat up and shouted for the other Goblins to *stop*, or go somewhere else.

They did, grumbling. She was Chieftain, after all. Rags turned over in her blankets and tried to sleep. But she couldn't. There was something on the wind. She sat up and glared at Pyrite. He shrugged apologetically.

Three Goblins, all of whom were linked. In some way, they were chosen. But what did it mean? What was their purpose? Did they have a purpose? The three sat, feeling restless and waiting. A faerie might have said their destinies drew closer, but there were none to watch and listen. Frost Faeries were leaving this world, and those that still remained did not

watch Goblins. Never Goblins. They might cry if they did, and the fae did not like to weep for the past.

The next day dawned slowly. And for the Goblins of the Flooded Waters tribe, it was an interesting day. It was always interesting when their small leader woke up. They woke up, yawning, searching for food or worms or bugs to eat, and looked around. Waiting. They didn't have a purpose, like every other species. Theirs was only survival. Their Chieftain decided what to do.

And her name was Rags.

His name was Pyrite. And he had bad gas. It might have been last night's jumbled soup containing some slightly rotting Mothbear flesh. Or it could be the tree bark he'd been munching on, or the colony of black beetles and larvae a Goblin had dug up. Pyrite had gotten a handful of them and crunched the beetles down. Or maybe it was the soap?

The Hobgoblin sat by the embers of the fire as the day fought the night. It was that ghostly hour before true day, where the light had begun to illuminate the world. The hour before birds woke up, a ghostly moment where everything seemed asleep.

He farted. The Goblins around him groaned. One threw a rock. It bounced off Pyrite's back and the Goblin shifted. Yes, it was probably the soap.

It was high quality stuff. The Hobgoblin looked down at the lump in his hands. The Flooded Waters tribe had stolen it from a caravan a day ago. It was bright blue, nearly perfectly clear the entire way through, and smelled of sandalwood and something else. Something...turquoise.

Smells were like colors to Pyrite. Smells were taste, color, feelings—the Goblin sniffed the soap he was holding appreciatively. He nibbled at it. It certainly didn't taste as good as it smelled.

Pyrite would be the first to admit that he wasn't that smart. He was just a former Goblin Chieftain of a small tribe that specialized in mining. Sure, they'd done a bit of smelting and attempted some armor crafting of their own to limited effect, but he considered himself a rather weak example of what a Chieftain could be. He wasn't that smart about a lot of things.

For instance, he *thought* that soaps were a product of some plants, namely the ground up roots which, when combined with water, created a nice lather for people to use. Of course, that was some kinds of soap; it was also possible to mix leftover fat and oil with some ashes to create another variant of the stuff. That was probably what he tasted here. Pyrite's palate detected traces of lye, which made sense since this was high-quality lye soap probably intended for a Human marketplace.

Of course, he could be completely mistaken. He wasn't that smart. The Hobgoblin chewed thoughtfully, feeling the soap dissolve in a pleasant way in his mouth. He didn't mind the taste. The Hob had eaten far worse things than soap. Huge insects, rocks, dirt, other dead Goblins...soap wasn't a problem.

He didn't need to eat the soap, strictly speaking. But if he didn't, who would use it? Certainly not the other Goblins. Soap was a useless product to them by and large. It smelled good, but Goblins didn't wash.

Rags did. She'd picked up the basics of hygiene somewhere and forced her Goblins to adopt a variation of it. But that was only to the extent where if a Goblin's hands had a *lot* of ick stuck to them they had to swish it around in water or rub it off first. Washing each time with hot water and soap was something only other species did.

Of course, Rags might use one bar or two herself. Pyrite nibbled at a bit more soap as he thought. But she wouldn't use much, and the other Goblins would probably cut it up, hoard the shiny fragments of soap until they got dirty, and then toss it when they got bored. Or eat it.

The last of the blue bar disappeared into Pyrite's mouth. He grunted. This time he could definitely feel the pressure building. Yes, the soap was giving him gas. He'd heard that some kinds of soap used toxic plants, which presumably meant you weren't supposed to eat them. But again, he was used to eating unhealthy things. He was a Goblin, and more than that, a Hobgoblin, one of the giants and leaders of his kind. He could eat almost anything.

And it was a habit for him to always chew something. Pyrite fished around in the wax bundle sitting in front of his crossed legs and came up with a red bar of soap. It was flecked with bits of yellow inside and it was semi-transparent and smelled spicy. He eyed it appreciatively and then took a bite.

He liked to eat. Eating was productive for him. It helped him build fat, and fat was important in case he fought or starved. Pyrite had no knowledge of the biological issues caused by excessive weight gain, and if he had, he wouldn't have cared particularly much. His argument, if he'd been pressed to make it, would be simple.

Fat was important for Goblins, far more than for Humans or other races. That was because Goblins did not enjoy the security of a set food source, by and large. Starvation was a facet of life, not an event to be avoided by most tribes. Additionally, Goblins had to fight for their lives on a regular basis.

Everything in the world wanted to kill them, and lacking armor that was specially crafted for their kind, a Goblin had to rely on their ability to dodge or survive something like an arrow hitting them. As Pyrite was definitely not shaped correctly for any kind of traditional armor, the layers of fat on

his body were his only shield. Ergo, gaining weight was, for him, a necessary task until it began to impede his movement or health in a dramatic way.

That was what he would have said if anyone asked him. But no one did. Pyrite was known to be a silent character of few words. And he wasn't that smart.

The Hob had gotten through the red bar of soap, and was looking for the pink one he'd spotted earlier, when Rags woke up. He paused in the act of calculating how much the soap was worth—by his rough estimates, he'd probably eaten a few hundred gold pieces worth of the stuff, especially if it was going to be used by the nobility. The sun had risen high enough to illuminate the world and Rags was up. He could tell because she was shouting.

Up, *up!* Goblins stirred, groaning at the young Goblin's voice. But they got up quickly; a slow Goblin was a dead Goblin, and faster still because they could smell food cooking.

Pyrite carefully bundled up the soap he'd been eating and lurched upright. His legs weren't asleep though he'd been sitting for hours; he had taken care to adjust his position throughout the night and stretch them now and then. He moved quickly and slipped into the front of the line for one of the soup pots before the other Goblins could get there.

That was the beauty of Rags' tribe. What elevated it above all others, save perhaps Tremborag's Goblins. As the Goblins woke up and poked each other, feeling their empty stomachs grumble, there was *already* food. Because the [Cooks] and [Stirrers], the less advanced Goblin version of [Cook], had woken up an hour before the others and begun making food.

Organization. It was a foreign concept to most tribes. Pyrite's belly grumbled as he sniffed the air and detected a good deal of flour, butter, and

animal fats in today's soup. Not much meat which was normal, but quite a good bit of the spices they'd stolen yesterday. The Goblins would eat well again.

And best of all, they didn't have to eat their own dead. It was an unspoken thing among Goblins, who rarely spoke anyways, but everyone knew that in times of hunger, meat was often the most plentiful food source around. But they didn't relish that knowledge because that meant the meat they were eating was their own kind, chopped up, boiled, or sometimes eaten raw.

Of course, the Goblins ate it. But contrary to what other species might have assumed, not a single Goblin *liked* eating their fallen. It was something they did to survive. So given half a chance, dead Goblin would *not* be on the menu. Pyrite took a big bowl of soup appreciatively from the Goblin in charge of serving, sniffing it. Yes, there was nothing like non-meaty soup to raise his spirits for the day. Anyways, he liked fish more than red meat. Most Goblins did.

Rags was already sitting by her personal campfire as Pyrite approached. He didn't bother with a spoon, but gently sipped at the bowl as he walked towards her. She was sitting on a log.

They were in a forest by a lake. It was, in fact, the same forest by the same lake they'd been camped at for quite a while. It was their semi-permanent home at this moment. For good reason.

The lake had fresh water so long as no Goblin had peed into it, and the forest had useful wood for fires, equipment, and so on. There was wildlife nearby, and the branches provided some protection from the snow and cold winds. That wouldn't be an issue as the world continued to warm, but it had been one of the concerns that made Rags camp here.

And one last thing. The forest by the lake was placed near several smaller cities and towns. It was the perfect place to strike from. Already, the Flooded Waters Goblins had raided several caravans on the road and plundered a few farms.

Nonviolently. That was to say, the Goblins came in, aimed crossbows, chased the Humans away and didn't kill anyone unless they were attacked first. It was a good system. And it had made their little tribe rich on the spoils, even if what they got was sometimes less useful, like soap.

“Pyrite.”

Rags was sitting on her log. Pyrite sat in the dirt, noting that she'd already gotten halfway through her bowl. One of the perks of being Chieftain was that she didn't have to line up. That was right and proper. He grunted at her, but said nothing. She eyed him.

She was probably holding a grudge from last night. Pyrite still felt gassy, but held it in as he ate. Rags looked at him, and then around her bustling camp.

“Last night. Anything happened?”

She still pronounced the words with difficulty, but her ability to speak in the common tongue was far better than it had been. She was a quick learner. It had taken Pyrite years to learn how to speak, and that was with a dedicated teacher. He shook his head.

“Silent, Chieftain.”

That was all he said throughout breakfast. When he'd finished his bowl of soup, Pyrite put it by the fire to be picked up by one of the Goblins on bowl-picking-up duty and opened the satchel of soaps again. He selected the pink one, and Rags edged upwind from him.

Why didn't the soaps make his farts smell good? It was a mystery. Pyrite sniffed the soap. Some kind of perfume. Too cloying for his tastes. He began to nibble it anyways.

In a few minutes, a Goblin passed by their fire. He picked up the bowl Pyrite had put on the ground and the one Rags tossed at him. He wandered off with the stack of bowls, bringing them towards a Goblin who was filling up more bowls with soup for Goblins in line.

Pyrite watched the Goblin go off. He must have had the duty to pick up empty bowls for the day. And the Goblin pouring soup had that duty as well. No matter how many times he saw it, the Hobgoblin was always impressed. Because the fact that those two Goblins had woken up and *remembered* what they were supposed to do was a sign that Rags was a great Chieftain.

She had brought organization and systems to this tribe. She and she alone had done that. No other tribe save for Tremborag's had implemented daily work rosters, much less a rotating duty schedule. And Tremborag's tribe had only developed such systems through the efforts of many, many Hobgoblins and out of sheer necessity. But Rags had come up with it all on her own. With her head.

She was a genius. The other Goblins knew it. It wasn't that they used that word lightly; most of them didn't know what that word meant at all. But it was clear that Rags thought where other Goblins didn't. She'd taught them how to make crossbows, created a unit of Goblins who used the deadly twenty-foot-long pikes made out of wood and scrap metal, and found a way to scavenge and steal enough food each day so that they didn't have to eat their own.

And she was so *young*. Pyrite glanced at Rags. Yes, young. He wasn't sure how young and she had never said, if she even knew, but she was

clearly outstanding. She was like he was, in fact. Extraordinary. Pyrite only wondered why she hadn't become a Hob yet.

The system was simple among Goblins and universally understood. If you were special, you'd turn into a Hob. That meant getting bigger in some way, stronger, and generally, smarter. Hobs were natural leaders, material for Chieftains, and savage fighters. They could stand toe-to-toe with the average Silver-ranked adventurer and were smart enough to use tactics in battle or implement their Chieftain's orders with finesse.

Rags wasn't a Hob. She should be. But she wasn't. It was one of the puzzles Pyrite was working on in his head. He had a few. He thought about many things, but didn't have solid answers for a lot of them because he wasn't as smart as Rags. He wondered why Rags wasn't a Hob, first off.

He wondered how magic worked and if he could teach himself some. He hadn't found a spellbook yet, but he had hopes of convincing Noears to teach him when the Goblin had time.

He thought about the last Goblin King, and why he had died. Pyrite wondered why the Goblin King, Velan, had been known as Velan the *Kind*. He wondered what that Goblin King had known, what he had thought.

Pyrite sometimes questioned what the stars were. They hung in the sky at night. But why only at night? And why were some different colors? What did they mean? Also, why did their positions change with the seasons? He'd tried mapping them over the years, but he'd given up. Not enough parchment to be scavenged.

He wanted to know what Rhir was like. Goblins knew of it as a place where death was kinder than living. But what was it *like*? And what was Chandrar like, or Baleros, or Terandria? Most Goblins had never heard of those continents, but Pyrite had.

And how had Tremborag turned into the giant form he used to slaughter those Gold-rank adventurers in battle? Pyrite had seen him do that once before, when he was young and still living in the mountain. Before he'd run away. How had he done that? Could other Hobs do the same?

Exactly what was the thing Garen Redfang had shown Tremborag in secret, the thing that had convinced the Great Chieftain to ally with him and Rags' tribe? Pyrite had seen them talking with it. It had looked like a key, and both knew what it was. What did it unlock?

And what—

Pyrite farted. He blinked, and felt a bit of dirt hit him in the side of the head. He looked up and saw Rags poised to throw. She showered him in dirt and Pyrite closed his eyes. She edged around the fire and he sighed.

These were just idle thoughts. He had many of them. Pyrite sometimes wondered if he thought too much. Probably. But it was good to think, and for Rags' tribe to have systems that made sense.

Already her Goblins had learned to fight in a different way, in formation with the aforementioned pikes. They had adopted crossbows for use alongside their slings, and had begun to train in their off time thanks to the Redfang Goblins. They had begun to learn different things.

They were growing smarter. It might not apply to every Goblin, but as a whole, the intelligence of the tribe had risen notably from the average tribe. Pyrite knew that; his tribe had been competent enough, being able to mine and sort out minerals from rocks when he'd shown them, but he'd still had to direct his Goblins and manage them constantly. These Goblins had begun to think about what they should do in a given situation.

And they were the same Goblins. But smarter. Yes, smarter. Pyrite had seen a Goblin who'd been in his tribe figure out how to start a fire. And Pyrite had been shocked, because when he'd been in *his* tribe, the said

Goblin had injured himself twice by sticking his hand into a fire and screaming when it burned.

But that was to be expected. You see, Goblins stole *everything*. And what they couldn't steal, they copied. And what all the Goblins in Rags' tribe were stealing from her was intelligence.

Pyrite paused. Stealing might not be the best word, but it was appropriate. Perhaps...the huge Hobgoblin's forehead wrinkled with concentration. Goblins had no word for it, but the word 'borrowing' sprang to mind. It was an unfamiliar concept. Teaching? Perhaps teaching was it.

By and large, Goblins were only as good as their Chieftain. They learned from example, and so a tribe became molded after their Chieftain. Their best qualities were passed down, which was how Garen Redfang's tribe had become so mighty, and how Rags' tribe was learning to think.

It was a beautiful, wonderful thing. And it made Pyrite think on some nights that he'd made the right choice. To stick by Rags instead of abandoning her in the mountain. Because she could lead the tribes. She could become the Chieftain they needed. She might become a Lord. She was special.

The sun was rising. The Goblins chattered or ate silently. Rags got a second bowl of soup. And in Pyrite's mind, a few words joined together in his head.

The wretched few gather;

Under her command.

Her back they follow after;

She alone knows the plan:

To live and strive and struggle;

And claim a Goblin's land.

So we fight and travel;

Until our final stand.

Pyrite's nose wrinkled. Where had that come from? That was...odd. He'd heard similar words before, sung out loud by Humans shortly before his tribe had leapt out and slaughtered them. But why had he thought them?

They fit together, in a way he liked. Still, it wasn't that good. The entire thing was too simple, like he was.

Still, there was promise in them. 'Claim a Goblin's land' had a nice ring to it. With a bit of work, and more fancy words, it might be worth saying aloud. Pyrite considered writing it down for a second and then thought better of the idea. There was no point.

Besides, he couldn't write.

Time passed. Pyrite finished another bar of soap and gave up on eating the rest because Rags kept throwing things at him every time he farted. He wrapped the soap up in wax paper and fished around in a little bag he kept at his hip. He pulled out something else to eat.

It was a rock. Rags stared at Pyrite as he put one of the smooth stones he'd taken from the lake's bed into his mouth. It was hard, dirty from the pack, and had a bit of moss on it. He began to crunch it into pieces.

Smooth rocks were fun to eat. There was something satisfying about savoring their texture and then crunching them up into dust. Of course, they

weren't good to eat too much of, so Pyrite switched from the stones to thick slabs of bark taken from the trees when he got bored.

In time, other Goblins approached the fire. They were all important, and Rags and Pyrite greeted them with grunts, shoving over to make room around the fire. In time, all the Goblins that needed to be present were, and they looked at Rags expectantly.

They were Noears the Goblin [Mage], Poisonbite, a skirmisher and raid leader who liked to poison her daggers, Redscar, the former Chieftain of the Rockfall Tribe, and...Greybeard.

Pyrite eyed them all as they sat around the fire, saying little but speaking volumes with their actions. Goblin politics were complex, and each one represented a powerful voice in Rags' tribe. Each one was important.

Noears and Poisonbite were obvious. They were normal Goblins, not Hobs, but they represented Tremborag's faction that had broken away to join Rags. Noears was a [Mage], a rarity among Goblins, and he could throw lightning. That made him special. As for Poisonbite, she was a good leader and fighter, and that mattered because other Hobs had let her represent them.

Between them, they represented a solid portion of Rags' tribe, but it was the scarred warrior who sat on his haunches next to them who was perhaps the most influential figure besides Pyrite and Rags. Redscar represented the whole of the former Redfang tribe, the elite warriors that had united under Garen Redfang and then left to follow Rags. He was a fierce warrior and the one Rags listened to often in combat.

Next to him, the Rockfall Tribe Chieftain sat with a second bowl of soup in her hands. She was the Goblin who represented all the other tribes. She wasn't exceptional in any way, but she was a good shot with the

longbow she carried and she had a place here because the other former tribes wanted one of their own to be heard by Rags.

And the last was Greybeard. Pyrite included him in the group of counselors to Rags because the old Hobgoblin wandered over often. He liked to chatter during such sessions, but Rags put up with him despite that. That was smart.

Pyrite nodded to Greybeard and offered him some bark. The old Goblin laughed and sat next to Pyrite, warming his feet by the fire. He had a white beard and he was older than any other Goblin that Pyrite had ever met. By far.

Across the fire, Redscar was eying Greybeard. Pyrite could tell the other Goblin was wondering why Greybeard was here, but he said nothing since Rags did not. Pyrite knew Greybeard should be here. He was important. Very important.

He'd solved part of the mystery of Greybeard long ago. The rest Pyrite had been content to wait and find out later. He wondered if Rags would notice Greybeard for what he was first, or if he would tell her.

So. The other Goblins sat around the fire and waited for Rags to speak. Each one was a powerful lieutenant who could speak to her without fear. They all had their own opinions and desires, and so they came each morning to talk and sometimes argue and persuade Rags to listen to them.

They were *not* like the Hob factions under Tremborag. Not. But they were still representatives of different ideologies within Rags' tribe. It had to be that way, but the key was that they did not squabble for power. They had a Chieftain, that was that. There was no...ranking between them.

Goblins were.

Today's strategy meeting was about what to do today. Pyrite listened.

“Should raid more caravans. More food. More steel. Good steel.”

Poisonbite sat forwards at the fire, looking eager. Of course, she had been used to raiding for supplies since that was her old job in Tremborag’s mountain. She liked the way Rags did things. Outnumber the caravans, scare them away, and best of all, you didn’t have to risk getting hurt. You just scared the Humans and let them run.

“Should find better place. Too much same spot is bad. Go south.”

A dissenting opinion came from Redscar. He crossed his arms, looking annoyed. His posture spoke as much as his words. His opinion was clear. He wanted to find a more defensible location. Actually, he wanted to go back to his home in the High Passes. The Redfang tribe clearly wanted an actual fight, not raiding, and they were growing antsy with inaction.

“South? Towards Goblin Lord? Yes. Lots of fighting there. Bad fighting! Or want to hide?”

A cackling laugh came from Greybeard as he gobbled down another bowl of soup. Everyone stared at him, and Rags turned to Noears.

“Not Goblin Lord. You. You said there is another tribe. Where?”

She had a map. Noears squatted by it, scratching at the holes in his head where his ears had been. He pointed.

“There, Chieftain. The Undercrawler tribe. They dig.”

“For stones?”

Pyrite sat up, intrigued. His love of mining had set his tribe apart from the rest. He liked shiny rocks, even if eating them didn’t agree with him. Noears shook his head.

“Just dig. Eats lots of bugs.”

Rags studied the map. Pyrite saw that they were a half a day's march from the Undercrawler Tribe's location. Half a day with Rags' [Fleet Foot] skill, that was. She nodded.

"Good. Could use diggers."

All the Goblins stared at her. Poisonbite scratched her head.

"Why, Chieftain?"

Rags scowled as if it was obvious.

"Good for digging! Dig holes for traps. Dig places to pee. Dig hole to toss stupid Goblins into!"

"Oh."

Pyrite nodded. He'd come up with the same conclusion himself. Rags pointed at the map, and then looked around the fire. She chewed her lip before giving orders.

"Find Undercrawler Tribe. Steal more food. Find better place. Go now."

Redscar smiled, satisfied, and the other Goblins nodded. Poisonbite didn't look too upset. Rags had outlined their strategy, which, translated into Pyrite's mind, meant first of all marching towards the Undercrawler tribe, no doubt to recruit them if possible. Rags had assimilated a few local tribes and she was clearly trying to increase her tribe.

Additionally, she'd also specified the need to raid for more food as a concern, which meant she was still focused on building up their supplies. That meant they'd hit a caravan on the road if they found one, although she clearly didn't think that was likely. Pyrite didn't either; word had spread about the marauding Goblins and only an idiot would take to the roads where they were nearby. Then again, idiots were plentiful.

Lastly, they were heading south and scouting for a second place to build their camp if they decided to head south. A good place to sleep and strike from. All things considered, she'd appeased everyone's wishes and set some good, open-ended objectives for her tribe to pursue in lieu of better ones. Of course, she hadn't said all that out loud but they'd all gotten that from her posture.

That was their mission for the day. The other Goblins nodded, and Pyrite began to execute Rags' orders. He was her second-in-command and thus expedited the process. He walked over to a Goblin loitering around, licking her empty bowl of soup, and poked her.

She looked at him. Pyrite grunted.

“Go that way. All.”

He pointed southeast, in the vague direction Rags had specified. The female Goblin nodded. She wandered off with her bowl, and poked another Goblin. She repeated more or less what Pyrite had said, then she and the Goblin she'd poked went off to find more Goblins to poke.

That was how the Goblins worked. True, they could have used a horn call or some other system, but Goblins were a social bunch. As soon as they realized something was happening, the other Goblins began to move with the rest, even if they didn't know exactly what it was they were doing.

Within twenty minutes, all the thousands of Goblins in Rags' tribe had packed what needed to be packed, lined up by the groups Rags had painstakingly assigned them to, and were marching away from their camp. It would have brought tears to the eyes of some military commanders, but it was normal for the Goblins. They didn't waste time since they didn't usually have time to waste.

The march out of the forest was swift. It was a small forest, for all the trees were very tall and wide. The Goblins began to cross into the relative open, sticking to hills, other stretches of rougher terrain, but not trying for too much stealth. Their advantage was the speed of their march and the fact that they were too big for most threats.

They crossed a road and scared a City Runner out of his mind. He ran away screaming and some of the Goblins raised their crossbows, laughing. They were shouted at by the Hobs in charge of their group and Rags. No killing Humans. Or Drakes. Or other species, if they could help it, really.

She had a soft spot for Humans, though. Her tribe had killed very few of them in the time that Pyrite had been with them, and she'd been only too willing to liberate the ones kept captive in Tremborag's mountain. She'd met a Human, once, it was rumored. A strange Human who lived around Liscor and fed the Goblins and Rags often.

Pyrite would have loved to meet her. He'd never met a Human who hadn't tried to kill him. His first memory of a Human was being stabbed by a farmer with a pitchfork on a raid. That day, the [Farmer] and his helpers had been too high-level and too many. They'd slaughtered the Goblins who'd come to steal eggs and chickens. Pyrite had crawled away in the mud and nearly bled to death.

Memories. The Hob walked along, munching on bark. It didn't bother him to remember. Not more than it did to know that the Goblins had come back the next night and slaughtered the entire farm. That was how it was. Death was a Goblin's life. There was nothing they could expect beyond that.

But they should. Pyrite's hand clenched and crushed the bit of bark. He stared at the fragments in his hand, and gave up eating for the moment. Instead, he increased his walking pace and moved past other Goblins

towards a pair of Goblins riding Carn Wolves and arguing hotly. Rags was shouting at Redscar as Pyrite approached.

“Will *not* fight. Pointless. Waste of Goblin lives!”

The warrior bared his teeth at Rags.

“Must fight. Not strong if not fight. Death means stronger Goblins who survive.”

“This means Goblins don’t die *and* win.”

Rags pulled out her black crossbow meaningfully. It was huge, and Redscar nodded grudgingly. But he pointed to the weapon.

“One. Many Goblins. Is not enough.”

The other Goblins had copied the design, but there was no making something of the same quality as the Dwarf-made bow that Rags had found. She scowled, but couldn’t come up with a good response.

His turn. Pyrite grunted and both smaller Goblins looked at him.

“Fight what?”

The Redfang leader grinned up at him.

“Eater Goats.”

“Eater Goats?”

The name of the monster was unfamiliar to Pyrite. Redscar nodded.

“Big herd in High Passes. Will fight. Eats Carn Wolves. Good fight. Makes tribe strong.”

Eater Goats? And they ate *Carn Wolves*? Pyrite was familiar with the huge red wolves that the Redfang tribe rode. And he wanted to train the new Goblins by making them fight those goats? He really was crazy.

“Stupid.”

Rags muttered the words, but Pyrite could see she was mulling the idea over. Her tribe was filled with Goblins, but only a few were elite warriors. Tremborag’s Goblins had quite a lot of battle-ready Hobs among them, and the Goblin Lord’s army had well-equipped Goblins of their own. Apart from her Redfang elites, Rags lacked the same kind of fighting force. Pyrite was about to ask Redscar exactly how many Goblins survived an encounter with Eater Goats when they heard a Goblin cry from the front.

Instantly, all three Goblins raced to the front of the line, argument forgotten. They saw a Goblin pointing and turned left, saw a tree.

And then saw what hung from it. They found the Undercrawler tribe too late. Humans had gotten there first.

A single tree had grown from the rocky hillside where the Undercrawler tribe had burrowed into caves and around rock. It was old, and bore no fruit. But something hung from it now. Awful rotten fruits, swaying in the breeze.

Bodies hung from the tree. Dark shapes, half-eaten by birds, some of them. Most untouched in the cold. The rest were piled around the tree, or lay where they had fallen.

Goblin bodies.

Pyrite’s foot crunched in the snow. He stepped towards the tree, looking up. Hung bodies. And the rest—he saw Goblins fallen, most of them—

Most unarmed. Pyrite looked around as the rest of Rags’ tribe halted and more Goblins entered the site of the massacre. They stared around. They could see what had happened.

Goblins fought. Goblins fell. But see how they fell? Most had wounds on their backs. Few had weapons. They hadn’t been fighting. This was a slaughter. And most had died in the first attack. The rest—

Had been hanged. Pyrite stared up at the ancient tree, branches carrying the swaying bodies. Hanged. What was the purpose? He couldn't understand it. Humans killed Goblins. But hang them?

“A warning. In case other Goblins come.”

Redscar stared up at the tree, jaw clenched, hand on his sword. Rags had dismounted. She pushed her Carn Wolf's head away from the body it was sniffing and looked around.

Death. It wasn't the first time Pyrite had seen it. But the destroyed tribe hurt his heart. He'd seen it too many times. He tried to push the feeling down, until he saw the message carved into the tree.

“What is this?”

Rags stared at the words. The other Goblins stared too, but most couldn't read. She could though, a little. And so could Noears. She called him over and the Goblin approached. The [Mage]'s face was silent as he stared at the words.

“What?”

Rags and the others stared at him. Noears spoke slowly.

“What happens to Goblins. What happens to filth.”

For a while, Rags stared at the words carved into the bark. Then she put a hand to the tree's trunk. Her hand glowed, and the bark began to smolder and ignite under her palm. Her face was—Pyrite turned away. He stared up at the body and then saw something.

A hand. Twitching. Was it just the wind? No. Pyrite watched and saw the hand moving again. One of the bodies overhead was still moving. One was still alive. Pyrite's eyes went wide. He grabbed the steel axe at his side

and raised it. Too short. The Goblin that was still moving was very small and hanged higher than he could reach.

“You!”

Pyrite turned and barked. A Goblin looked up at him. Pyrite pointed.

“*Cut!*”

The other Goblins saw the twitching Goblin. They crowded around the tree and several Goblins were thrown up. They clung to the bark and began to climb towards the branch the Goblin was hanging from.

Pyrite stood below the Goblin and stared up. The one that was alive was no more than a child.

He was still alive. The Goblins were too small, too *light* to hang properly. The rope had failed to break his neck, and so the child had suffocated here. Pyrite caught him as a Goblin cut the rope and cradled him in his arms. The Goblin gasped and choked.

Dying.

“Here.”

Rags appeared with a potion. She threw it and Pyrite caught the small vial. He stared at her for a moment. Any other Chieftain wouldn’t waste a potion on a single Goblin. He wasn’t sure he would. She glared at him.

No time to question. Pyrite carefully uncorked the vial and poured it sparingly onto the child’s throat. The small Goblin began to shudder.

The healing potion began to reduce the swelling around his neck, cure the puffy skin around his face. But he was so cold and small. Pyrite held him. The Goblin child was gasping, but his eyes were closing.

“Don’t sleep. Open eyes.”

Pyrite spoke to him. The Goblin gasped, and Pyrite slapped his face gently. He couldn't sleep. If he did, he would die. Healing potions only cured so much. If the body was out of energy, they died.

The child's eyes began to close. Pyrite roared at him.

"Stay open!"

An eye opened. Two crimson eyes looked into Pyrite's. He cradled the child and saw Rags approaching. Pyrite lowered the child and Rags stood over him.

Somehow, the Goblin recognized Rags as a Chieftain. He gurgled, choked. Rags knelt by him.

"Who did?"

She spoke in the Goblin tongue. The child gurgled, coughed. His eyes were flickering. Rags knelt and Pyrite poured more healing potion on his neck. Rags bent her head by the child's.

"Who? Tell me. Who?"

A whisper. The Goblin reached out and Rags grabbed his hand. She bent over him as Pyrite felt the child growing colder. He shouted for a blanket, a fire.

The hand went limp in Rags' hand. The child's lips stopped moving. He closed his eyes. Pyrite grabbed his shoulder and shook him. Roughly. The Goblin's head bounced, but he didn't open his eyes.

"Open!"

He couldn't sleep. If he did, the healing would—Pyrite felt someone grab his arm. He realized the child was cold. Very cold. He looked over his shoulder and saw the Rockfall Chieftain was holding him. She shook her head.

Slowly, Pyrite let go of the small Goblin. He put him on the ground and stood up. The empty potion bottle dropped from his hand. Then Pyrite slowly bent and picked it up. Not good to waste—waste—

He looked around. The other bodies hung from the tree. They lay on the ground, silent, unmoving. Rags stood in the snow, looking around. Her Goblins were looking at her.

Her eyes were bleak when they fixed on Pyrite. She looked past him and at the Rockfall Chieftain instead. She nodded to the Hob.

“Burn tree. Leave rest.”

She turned away. Pyrite stood in the snow until the tree went up in flames. The bodies burned and fell, and he placed the Goblin child on the pyre and left.

For the council of war.

There was a Human town nearby. A large one, with guards and walls. It had probably been the one to send the adventurers after the Undercrawler tribe, but it wasn't certain. The Goblins were split.

Half wanted to destroy the town. The other half...didn't see the point. Tremborag's former Goblins were among the latter, surprisingly. They were all for slaughter, but they'd agreed with Rags' non-violence policy when it came to Humans. Don't hurt them, and they weren't such a large threat.

Redscar and the Rockfall Chieftain were for vengeance. So was Pyrite. But he sat in silence, waiting, watching Rags. She kept staring at her hand, the hand she'd held the child's with.

She did not kill Humans. She liked them. At last, the Goblins stopped quarrelling and fell silent. Looking at her. There was no proof. Anyone could have sent the adventurers. They could have come from anywhere. But it was the town, Pyrite was sure. They had asked, and a group had come to slaughter the tribe.

But there was no proof. And everyone was watching Rags, now. Did she side with the Humans? The Undercrawler tribe had surely raided the town or nearby villages and farms for food when they were hungry. Maybe they'd killed some Humans who'd been alone. Maybe. Probably.

That was life. But in the end Rags had looked up and spoken.

“We attack.”

An hour later, the Goblins were within sight of the town. They marched on it. Quietly.

At first, the few guards on the walls didn't seem to realize what they were seeing. But as Goblins appeared in the distance, marching towards the ten-foot-high walls, they raised the alarms. Pyrite saw people appearing on the walls in the distance, raising bows. There were a lot of soldiers at the gates.

He didn't care. Rags raised her arm, and crossbows snapped up. Goblins began to throw rocks from slings and loose bolts into the air. The defenders returned fire, but they had only a few bows, and Hobs with their own weapons picked them off one at a time.

The gates opened, and an armored group of riders rode out. They began to race around the Goblins, only to find a wall of terribly long pikes swinging out to face them. The Goblin pikes charged, and the riders had to retreat. Two were too slow and their mounts were impaled by the charging Goblins. The rest fled back into the gates.

Pyrite marched behind the Goblins with pikes, hearing the *thunk* of crossbows firing, hearing a scream as a Goblin was hit by an arrow. A [Mage] blasted Goblins from the battlements for a moment before Noears hit him with lightning and arrows struck the mage from twenty bows.

The gates were thick and heavy, meant to withstand a monster attack. Pyrite and eight Hobs grabbed a battering ram that Rags had ordered built and *slammed* it into the gates. It took three hits before the wood began to splinter. The Goblins behind them pushed, and the wood broke.

The Goblins streamed into the city with a howl, meeting the defenders in a scrum at the gates. The Humans were numerous. They screamed in fury, defending their homes. The Goblins howled and rushed them.

Pyrite was first into the fray. He charged into a man with a sword and felt the sword bite into his stomach. But the Human hadn't expected Pyrite to run into the blade. The Hob grabbed the screaming man and struck him once with the axe.

He was wearing a helmet, but the Human died anyways under the crushing blow. Pyrite picked him up and *heaved* the man back towards his friends. The armored corpse knocked over several Humans and the smaller Goblins swarmed them.

Blood and sweat and heat. The cold and the burning cut in his stomach were distant sensations to Pyrite. He strode forwards, and saw a man with a heavy mace bashing down a Hob. He was an adventurer; his mace shone and he had a shield that was deflecting every weapon that came at him. Pyrite charged towards him and the adventurer turned.

Silver-rank, probably. He was confident, trusting in his shield to protect him. The adventurer turned from the Hob and shouted.

"Come on, you damn Goblins! Fight me!"

He raised his shield and Pyrite's axe crashed into it. The shield didn't break, and the adventurer barely staggered. He lashed out with his mace. It had a spiked head and tore away part of Pyrite's stomach. The Hob grunted, stepped back.

"Come on, come *on!* What are you waiting for?"

The Human snarled as he lashed out at Pyrite. The Hob had no shield and blocked with his axe. He was hit in his arm, and again in his chest. Both times the mace came away bloody, but Pyrite said not a word.

He fought silent. Where the other Hobs and Goblins around him shrieked in fear and battle fury and howled as their friends and family bled and died, Pyrite hacked and cut and sometimes dodged in a void of sound.

It bothered the Human. Pyrite's expression never changed. He just stared at his opponent as the Human cursed at him. He swung his mace and Pyrite knocked it back with his own axe. He swung, and again the magical shield came up, taking his blow.

Stalemate. The Human's friends were dying, but he was helping hold the line. He raised his mace and Pyrite paused. He looked past the Human and spoke in a level, normal voice.

"What's that?"

He pointed. The Human's head instinctively turned. Too late, it snapped back. This time his shield was too low. Pyrite buried the axe in the Human's shoulder, grabbed the screaming Human's mace, and buried it in his head. He stepped back, breathing hard as the line of warriors broke without the adventurer to hold it.

"Idiot."

He wrenched his axe free and walked past the Human. It was surprising how many times that worked. But no one expected a Hobgoblin to say

anything in their language and so sometimes they looked, or just hesitated for a moment. A moment was all Pyrite needed.

The rest of the Humans began to crumble once the Goblins got past the gates. Rags' tribe outnumbered the Humans far too greatly, and her tactics were superior to theirs. She charged her pikes into the Humans while her crossbows hammered them. Pyrite didn't fight another Human; the combination of the pikes and Redfang warriors waiting behind them was an impenetrable wall that the Human defenders couldn't break through.

They found the majority of the townsfolk clustered in the square. They'd tried to flee through the opposite gates, but a second force of Goblins from the rear had blocked their escape. Poisonbite and her warriors had cut down several of the Humans, but they stopped when Rags strode towards them.

“Hold.”

The Humans stared at the small Chieftain with horror and fear. She looked at them. One of the Humans spat—the others dragged him back, afraid of her. But they hated her, and the other Goblins. Pyrite saw it in their eyes. Rags stared at them and then turned to him.

“Bring me rope.”

The Humans stirred. Some cried out in horror. Others began to beg. Pyrite stared at Rags and then got her the rope. He didn't know what she was going to do.

She hung the bodies from the houses. Not live ones, but the dead Humans. When Pyrite heard her orders he felt relieved. Relieved because she wasn't retaliating in kind? The Humans would have hanged them all. He thought about that as he oversaw the Goblins clambering on the rooftops.

They hanged the dead adventurer and guards from the rooftops, a grim mockery of what had come before. Then Rags pointed, and Goblins streamed into buildings, forcing out screaming Humans, coming out with grain, barrels of goods, sacks and objects like hammers, shears, buckets, pans.

They looted the town for an hour and left. They took everything they could grab and carry. Food, supplies—

The Humans tried to resist once. A man tried to stop them from taking some jewelry, saying that it was his wife's. Pyrite thought of the dead child and broke his jaw and arm.

The Flooded Waters tribe left the town in ruins. Both gates were broken, their defenders slaughtered. But they left the people alive. Poisonbite had argued against it, and so had Redscar. They didn't want to leave witnesses.

Rags didn't care. Pyrite had seen her looking at the Humans, looking at children, and, for some reason, a young woman with brown hair. She'd forbidden the Goblins from touching them.

So they'd left. There was no celebration as the Goblins marched back towards their camp, laden with their spoils. Not this time.

It was a silent camp that ate and sat around the lake. Pyrite washed his wounds in the water, watching the dried blood float into the lake. It hurt, but he didn't want a healing potion. That was a waste.

The mood was too quiet around camp. Goblins sat around, poking with sticks at the ground, not doing much of anything. They should have been celebrating. They'd won a battle. But what they'd seen bothered them.

It bothered Rags. And Pyrite. And because their Chieftain was silent, the Goblins learned from her. Pyrite stared at a young Goblin, practically no more than a child, staring moodily at the lake. He felt that shouldn't be so. They had to smile. If they didn't smile, what was the point of being alive?

After some thought, Pyrite approached the small Goblin. He poked him. The Goblin looked up. Pyrite nodded to the lake.

“Can swim?”

The Goblin stared at him, and then nodded cautiously. Pyrite smiled.

“Good.”

Then he seized the Goblin, lifted him up, and *threw* him across the water. The small Goblin flew across the lake, screaming until he splashed into the water.

Every Goblin head in the vicinity had turned the instant Pyrite had seized the Goblin. They stared at him, afraid he was angry. They watched the Goblin splash down, spluttering, and then swim towards the edge. Pyrite smiled again.

“Next?”

He looked at some of the small Goblins, the children. They edged away from him. Then a brave young female Goblin stepped forwards. She shrieked as he lifted her, and then tossed her into the air.

She flew far. Pyrite was a Hob and she was very light. The other Goblins watched with open mouths as the Goblin child cannonballed into the water. Half seemed perplexed, but the other half caught on.

Pyrite threw the Goblin. Throwing was bad. It hurt if you hit the ground. But what if you landed in the water? In that case—

The next child went screaming into the lake, but he was laughing when he climbed out. And then other Goblins approached. Pyrite hurled an adult into the water and as the Goblin climbed out he shouted at the other Goblins, grinning and miming flapping his wings. Then they *all* wanted to try.

Rags found Pyrite and a group of over twenty Hobs hurling Goblins into water. The sound had drawn every Goblin in camp, and the Hobs seemed to be enjoying the activity. They were competing to see who could throw Goblins the furthest, highest, or make them puke as they spun into the lake.

Pyrite turned, sweating in the cold, bleeding slightly from his stomach where his wounds had opened up, to see Rags standing with arms folded. She stared pointedly at his stomach.

“Pointless.”

He shrugged. She was very smart sometimes, but not all the time.

“Fun, Chieftain.”

She looked past him as a screaming Goblin cartwheeled into the water, much to the entertainment of every other Goblin watching. She shook her head.

“Stupid.”

She turned to go. Pyrite grabbed her. Rags struggled, shouted, but it was too late. He *heaved*, and his Chieftain went flying.

She was very light. The other Goblins stopped and stared as they saw their Chieftain arc high into the sky before crashing into the water. The

entire time, Rags' eyes were locked on Pyrite's face.

She glared at him the entire time she was flying, until she hit the water. That was rather impressive, actually. Rags swam out of the lake quickly, unlike the other floundering Goblins. That surprised Pyrite until he thought about it for a moment. Of course. The Flooded Waters tribe was good at swimming.

That night, Goblins played in the water, laughing, some drowning until they were fished out. But they were laughing. The water was very cold, but they didn't care. It was something new. And that night, Pyrite sat by his fire, wet, cold, bleeding a bit, but better.

Around him, Goblins were sleeping. Pyrite was still up. He was always awake during the nights. He'd had a few good hours of sleep earlier, and it was important for him to be up while Rags slept. Just in case. As the fires dimmed and Goblins began snoring around him, Pyrite stared into the flames.

And spoke. Quietly, giving voice to words in his chest.

"We are not monsters yet;

But we do not forget;

We are lost, outcasts all.

I caught him too late. His sigh—

A shudder. Last goodbye.

Time passes, cities rise and nations fall;

And yet they will always hate us all.

Goblins. Why do they hate us so?

Why does the wind blow?

I suppose I will never know.”

He paused, but no one had heard him. Pyrite whispered the words a few more times. Not bad. But not good. He’d used ‘all’ twice, and he wasn’t sure about the second to last line. Why does the wind blow? A bit too silly, he felt. But it had promise.

Pyrite thought the rhyming at the end of the lines was important. But he wasn’t sure. It sounded pleasing to his ears, though. He wondered if other species had something like this. Songs? No, this was different.

He sat, and slowly fished out a burnt out coal from the fire. It was still very hot. He bit into it anyways, and chewed slowly as the night ended and the sun began to rise. This was how he lived. Day by day, hour by hour. Sometimes he despaired. Other times he laughed.

But always, he dreamed of a day where Goblins would live freely. He looked south and added one more thought to the list in his head. He wondered if there was a way for Goblins to live in peace with other races.

Probably not. But he waited for Rags to wake. To wake, and show them, show all Goblins she was worthy of being a Chieftain. Of being a Goblin Lord.

Of someday, perhaps...

Being a King.

The night ended. Rags woke up, this time without a bad smell in her nose. She yawned as her camp began to stir with the dawn, and spotted a familiar shape. Pyrite, the former Goldstone Chieftain, sat by a fire, chewing on something. She grunted, pleased he hadn't fallen asleep. But then, he never did.

He was dependable, like that. Rags got up, stretching, and saw Pyrite's head drift towards her, and then back to the fire. She shook her head as she wandered over to where the Redfang warriors were already training for the morning.

Some days Rags wondered what Pyrite was thinking. The huge Hobgoblin sat in front of the fire, chewing calmly, staring into the flames. He was always so calm. And he never seemed bothered by anything.

He was delightfully simple, Rags concluded. He could think deeply at times, but by and large he was uncomplicated and straightforward. She envied him for his narrow view of the world. It wasn't easy being her. Not easy at all. She walked away, and began thinking of what to do next. Time to lead her tribe again. Life was hard.

But she was up to the challenge. And behind her, the Goldstone Chieftain sat and chewed, and thought.

Then he farted.

1.02 C

I have a confession to make. When I first came to this world, I was excited. I thought I could be someone else. They told me I could be a hero. But it turned out that people don't change that easily. Cowards are still cowards. And I was a coward.

But then I was afraid when I learned that people could change. People could change entirely, and that scared me as much as not changing. Then, I was frightened of what I might become.

Now I know the truth. People don't change so easily. They can, but what this world does isn't change us. Rather, it shows us who we are. Heroes. Cowards.

And monsters. And I am all three. They call me a hero, I know I am a coward, and I have a monster in my soul. The devil dances in the mirror and laughs. I call his name.

Tom.

“Tom? Hey Tom, you’ve got snow in your hair.”

A tentative voice wakes me up from my thoughts. I pull myself up on my horse and brush at my head. I don't feel any wet. And when I find what's stuck there, I realize it isn't snow. It's a flower petal. White, beautiful, fallen from high overhead.

White petals. They float down softly among the sounds of people cheering from the rooftops of houses. I look to my left, the little petal in my hands. Richard grins at me and tugs the hat on his head a bit higher. It should be silly to wear a cowboy hat over armor, but I have to admit, Richard pulls the Stetson off quite well. Maybe it's because he's also mounted.

Nothing like a cowboy [Knight] to get the crowds going. I flick the petal towards him as my own horse plods along the paved street.

"Nice crowd."

"You should smile and wave at them. They're cheering for you as well."

"Mm. That's because they don't know me."

Richard shakes his head. I sigh, but obligingly wave a hand upwards. A few more people add their voices to the cheering. It's a small crowd, really. A thousand people in a city built to hold far more than that. But they gather, and around me, the others are waving, blowing kisses. They're glad to be here. And as the petals float down, I admit, so am I.

Petals. They're whiter than snow. In Rhir, snowfall is cold and wet. And often—tainted. Grey, or sometimes black, by whatever curse lies upon the land. It's said the black snow is a product of the blighted lands themselves, and the people avoid touching it where it falls.

Not that that's a problem here. I look up, and up, my eyes travelling across sky bridges, made of wood and stone, buildings which reach up like small skyscrapers, layers of houses, shops, and more packed into one place. It's like and unlike a city from my world in so many ways. The height is there, yes, but the aerial walkways and ramparts? No.

"New York City looked like this, once, you know."

"Really?"

I look back at Richard. He nods.

“Keith told me. He’s into architecture.”

“Engineering major. Right.”

It’s funny, I’d forgotten. But of course, Keith would have been a freshman in Pennsylvania. Lehigh University. It’s so strange. I never went to college, but I can’t imagine being that certain about what I’d want to do with my life that early. I didn’t know what I wanted when I was taken, that’s for sure.

“So New York looked like this a while back? Why’d they stop?”

“I don’t know. Construction costs? People falling? You should ask him.”

I glance back down the line of people on horseback, catching sight of Keith. I hesitate, shake my head.

“Nah. I’m not that curious.”

“Come on, Tom.”

“Nah. But I will go for a walk up there sometime. Looks like fun. So long as you don’t slip.”

“Yeah. Emily’s going to hate it, though.”

“Oh? Why?”

“She gets vertigo something fierce. Maybe we can get a room on the ground floor, do you think?”

“Not sure. I guess that depends on the impression we make. Hey, I’m going to ride ahead, okay?”

“Alright, then.”

I gently nudge the horse I'm riding on with my heels. The brown creature grudgingly accelerates a bit while Richard slows his to hang back with the others. He makes it look so easy. He sits on his stallion like they've known each other for years. I can barely get my mare to stop.

Alone again. I know Richard's trying to be nice and talk to me, but I don't need it. I keep my horse more or less between the group from my world, the twenty or so Americans who were summoned to this world, and our escort. Soldiers ride ahead and behind me, armor gleaming, but showing evidence of battle. The people cheer us all the harder because of it.

We are heroes. And some of us are [Heroes]. I'm not.

Not anymore. I gave that up with everything else months ago. Now I'm just Tom. Thomas, if you're my mom. And I'm riding through the city as petals fall onto my shoulders and get caught in my hair. I look up again.

And the city takes my breath away.

So beautiful. The tangle of buildings and pathways through the sky really are a sight unique to this world. There are bridges large enough for horses to ride across, and for wagons to roll through! A city climbing to the sky. And why not? The people live close together, behind walls. Why not build a city like this, in this continent of ceaseless war?

This is Rhir. And this is the heart of the kingdom, the shield city known as Paranfer, whose walls have stood for thousands of years. But even here, behind the four great walls built by generations of the inhabitants, safety is not always guaranteed. As I look up, I see evidence of that in the form of watch towers, manned even in the capital city.

And, of course, we passed through the six successive outer walls of the city and the seventh, being built as we rode in. Each wall is taller than the last, and, of course, patrolled by guards. I'm told that with each new wall, a new layer of housing is added to the ones beneath. I wonder how the

architecture can handle it? The foundations of each building must be hundreds of feet deep. Or enchanted.

Probably enchanted.

In this sprawling, tightly-knit overgrowth of civilization, it's possible to walk up six stories and walk with the covered roofs of the city shielding you from the corrupted rain or snow that might pour down without warning, or venture far, far beneath, to the streets and gutters where the sewers run black, depositing their contents into the sea.

Apparently people live down there, in the sewers. The magical pollution does something to them. But whatever dangers the contamination might pose, it still runs into the sea. And there it flows west and north. Towards the edge of the world.

Beyond Rhir, there is no world. A few islands perhaps, and oceanic depths no one has explored. But beyond that? The end of the world. A great abyss from which no one returns. The world is flat, and you can sail right off it. Rhir sits at the edge of the world—so do the islanders, a group of strange foreigners who clash with Minotaurs and sometimes sail towards civilization.

Or so I've been told. I know only what other people tell me about this world. I have never left this continent, not in the months I've been here. And I've only ever seen this city once before.

My heart stirs as I watch the petals floating down. The people are still cheering above, waiting along the route of our procession. Not a lot of them, but some. They're shouting, crying out the rallying call of Rhir.

"The Walls stand!"

"The Blighted King sits upon his throne!"

“To the ends of the world and back! *Rhir!* The last war! The endless war!”

Fierce shouts, from men, women, and children alike. There’s no doubt in their voices, no sense of embarrassment for what they say. Each one is filled with burning pride in who they are, love for their country.

Patriots. It’s an odd thought. I feel a chill and look towards the palace rising above the rest of the city. It is gigantic, apparently taller than any other such building in the world. It was designed by Dwarfs, added to year after year, and made to never be taken. Yes, *Rhir* might be blighted, afflicted by dark magic, and attacked by strange new monsters year after year. Yes, the Demon King waits and sends his armies forth to bring down the walls.

But it is great for that reason. Because *Rhir* will not fall. It alone boasts the most skilled and deadly warriors from all races. The kingdom has ancient treasures, unyielding protectors, and its [King] is known throughout the world. All nations know of *Rhir*, and if the horns call, they send their armies. For if *Rhir* falls, the world is next.

...Or so I’m told. It sounds to me like *Rhir* is isolated, cut off from the rest of the world by the battle only the people here will fight. But to the people, their struggle is pride and purpose.

Another petal floats down. It’s truly beautiful, and I’m glad to see it. I’ve had enough of grey and black snow, or worse, red snow. I reach up as it flutters towards my face.

This petal is soft and cool, chilled by the air, but warming, like the weather. I catch it and sniff at it. The smell is sweet, vanishingly faint, and melancholy. Just as soon as I sniff, I sneeze. I wipe at my nose and feel my skin itching. I quickly brush the petal off and note that my skin is already turning red.

“Great. I think I’m allergic to that.”

Why can’t I have nice things? I sigh. I ride on, and hear a little voice.

Maybe because you’re not a nice person. Or maybe it’s genetics. Either way, you’d better hope you don’t inhale one of those or you might die of anaphylactic shock. Now, how funny would that be? There’s no EpiPen in this world. Go on, sniff another and see how fast your throat closes up.

It’s not a nice thought. I ignore it and sigh.

Come on, you can’t ignore me. Or rather, you. Is it me or you? Both? It’s like a thought you can’t ignore. Or a song. Remember the one about badgers?

“Goddamnit.”

The voice is back. I’m afraid it’ll plague me all day this time. My voice, to be exact. No one else’s. Nothing to be worried about. It’s just a voice. In my head. Everyone has a little voice in their head, right?

It doesn’t make me crazy. Even though I am insane. But [Lesser Insanity] isn’t...isn’t...

Fun? Entertaining? Totally batshit crazy? Where were you going with that one?

Let’s try this again.

Hi. My name is Tom. I’m a Level 28 [Clown]. Only, I’m retired. You’d never know it to look at me, as I ride through the streets of Rhir with an escort of soldiers and my friends. I look normal. Just a guy in slightly worn clothing, slightly overweight, but not as heavy as I used to be—I lost weight. I have scars you can’t see, and a funny walk. But that’s all. I’m white, American, and as bland as you can be.

I don't wear the face paint any longer. I don't color my nose red, or paint my face whiter than it usually is. I don't juggle, do tricks, or anything remotely funny if I can help it. I've given up being a [Clown]. I really have.

And I'm not insane. I'm not. Not entirely. Not yet.

Keep telling yourself that.

"Okay, maybe Richard was right."

I gently pull on the reins of my horse. She freezes, and I nearly topple off her. I groan, turn her around, and walk her back. Towards the others.

There they are, twenty of them. Not all clustered up at once, of course; they're riding in a procession, so it's two to four abreast, all moving slowly down the street. Not the widest of streets, either, and not one lined by cheering people, you'll note. This is one of the entry streets to Paranfer, and as such it's meant to be kept empty of all traffic except those going this way. The general citizenry stays above.

I was riding at the head of our little procession, but now I head back. There are four people there. Richard, our own southern cowboy [Knight], the leader of our ragtag group. Emily, another leader, beloved, a [Hydromancer]. And next to them Keith, a [Blacksmith] who wants to find out if there is an [Engineer] class, and Chole. Chole's a [Nurse].

"Tom!"

Richard breaks off from talking with Chole and the others at once. They all fall silent as I awkwardly guide my horse over to them. I see Emily actually pull her horse back a bit. That's fine. Understandable, even.

"Hey Richard, guess what? Turns out I'm allergic to the pretty flowers."

"Well, that ain't good. At least we're not being showered by the stuff, then."

Richard shakes his head. I turn my horse and fall in with him. Emily hesitates, but it's Chole who backs up until she's behind us. I ride next to Richard, pretending not to notice the way Keith stares at me. Of course, Richard acts like nothing's amiss. He's considerate like that.

"Reckon we'll be in the main part of the city soon. It's a big place, isn't it? I didn't see much of it the first time we were here, but we'll be going through a bigger section soon, with a larger escort."

"Are they actually going to throw a parade for us? I thought all of this was what we were going to get."

Emily waves a hand up at the balconies overhead. A girl cheers down at her, which doesn't in turn cheer her up. She wanted a parade, and we barely got that. I don't care. Keith looks as skeptical as Richard and I feel.

"I don't know. We're not exactly in favor, are we? It's only 'cause you and Richard are over Level 30 that we're getting acknowledged at all, right? For fighting Demons and monsters. Well, that and..."

He glances sideways at me. I ignore the look and hunch my shoulders.

How can you ignore a look and respond to it? Just say it out loud, Tom. We're getting invited back to the capital because you killed a bunch of innocent people. Wait, I mean, the Demons killed the innocent people and you killed them. That makes you a hero! Right?

Richard clears his throat.

"So long as we can get behind some actual walls for a spell, I'm grateful. And if the Blighted King wants to see us, that's fine. So long as we can impress His Majesty, that is."

He's looking at me now, too. I look up and meet his eyes.

"I'm done, Richard. I told you that."

He nods. Emily doesn't look convinced. Keith opens his mouth and Richard speaks.

"Look, we're here."

Our street opens and takes us into a grand plaza. One of many, but grand nonetheless. It's large enough to hold thousands of people, or at least, make us feel tiny as we enter it on horseback.

"Alright, we're here! Off the horses!"

As we enter the square, our leader calls out and I gladly slide from my saddle. I hear one of our number, Eddy, grumbling as we do.

"Why can't we ride to the palace? I can see it from here!"

"If you can see it, you can walk to it. Besides, some roads are foot traffic only. Stop complaining."

Vincent calls out as he helps Chole off her horse. Eddy mutters, but doesn't respond outright. He grumbled when we had to ride as well, since he wasn't used to riding in the first place. I guess he got used to it.

Now we're in the plaza, I look around. There are many roads entering here, and the ground has some kind of spiral pattern to it. The colored bricks make me feel as though I'm being drawn to the center.

"Pretty."

I say it to no one. Unfortunately, someone responds.

As lovely as a whirlpool. Do you think it's a spell? It might be. Anger the wrong person and you'll be sucked into the ground in the center, there. The center, right by the man with the stall selling daggers.

Why do I think like this? I sigh, take my mind off the idea of magical traps, and loiter with the rest of my group in the absent-minded sort of way crowds do when they're waiting for someone to tell them what to do next.

“Oh, look. Beggars!”

A soft cry comes up from one of the other girls. I look and see Cynthia pointing with dismay at a girl with a bowl sitting around the edge of the plaza. She’s young. Can’t be more than eight, perhaps. The attention of my group is drawn instantly to her, and her situation.

“We should give her something.”

“Why? Look, she’s probably fed—”

“You don’t know that!”

“Yeah, but if you give her money, what about everyone else? Look how many there are.”

“But she’s—”

“Tom, toss me a coin, would you?”

Richard settles the matter before it can turn into another argument. He raises a hand as he walks over to the girl, who looks up hopefully. I sigh and dig around in a pouch at my waist.

There’s a good twenty feet of distance between me and Richard, and it’s growing each time he takes a step. Still, that doesn’t matter.

I have a Skill.

You’ve got lots of skills, Tommy boy. You just don’t use them.

Ignore that. I have a good Skill. Not like the—others. The ones I received that night.

Oh, happy memories.

[Lesser Insanity]. [Horrific Laughter]. [Devil’s Luck]. [Greater Pain Tolerance]. And...[Weapon Proficiency: Knives]. Those are the skills I

received on the day when I went crazy. When I had a breakdown and slaughtered a group of Demon soldiers.

Correction: when you acted heroically. That's why you leveled, right? You were a hero! Sorry, I mean, [Hero]!

Ignore it. Ignore...since then I've leveled up four more times. I learned a few cool skills. The first is [Unerring Throw], which allows me to hit any target I aim at, so long as what I'm aiming at doesn't dodge or block, or if the throw's physically impossible for me.

Cue me tossing the silver coin to Richard, over the heads of everyone else. He catches it in one gauntleted hand and offers it to the kid. He kneels down with her and Cynthia and a few others go over. I stand back, counting up the coins we have now.

Some gold, some silver...one less. Not a lot; not if we're buying all the gear everyone wants. But why don't I think that'll stop Cynthia from demanding more coins for every child beggar we see? I sigh.

You don't really care.

I don't. It's true. But it is my job to manage the coin. I guess I can be okay with handing it out whenever anyone asks. Because that's my job in this group. Some people are leaders, like Richard and Emily, others have opinions like Eddy who knows a lot about games, and others...why do I feel like this is the student council and I'm back in High School? Maybe because I have a position very similar to that here.

Treasurer. Actually, I'm more like a glorified purse. I keep the money Richard and the others are given, and give it out only when everyone votes we use it. Or when Richard says. I also help make sure everyone gets food for the night, manage our supplies of potions and so on...it's not an important job. I do it because I won't fight. I refuse to fight.

I had enough of it after the night when Wilen died.

Squashy, squashy. Troll goes stompy. And little Tom goes crazy.

For a second I debate stabbing myself. Right in the eye, or the side.
Would that make the voice go away?

Try it and find out! One stab and everyone'll believe there's a voice in your head! Why not?

I hate you so much. Hate me. I know you're not real.

"...Tom! Tom! Get out of the way!"

A voice calls out. I look up, and realize someone's right on top of me. A scaly, orange face, glinting chainmail, a spear grasped by a claw-like hand—a lizard-guy is bearing down on top of me! Scratch that, a *lot* of lizard guys, marching in tight formation!

He's about to walk into me. I twist out of the way, gracefully for a guy my size. One step, and the huge lizard man misses me by a fraction of a millimeter. His buddies march past as well as I step away.

That's the second skill I learned. [Flawless Dodge]. It only works when I'm ready for what's coming at me, and I can't do it every time. But I feel pretty spry whenever it works.

"Company, halt! Stop running over civilians, you thick-scaled idiots!"

A voice shouts, and the lizard people stop instantly. They turn like a single unit, and I see another one striding towards me. She has black scales, a marked expression on her face, and a plumed helmet. Clearly an officer.

Or an enthusiastic cosplayer.

"Sorry about that. This lot is trained to walk over anyone in the way, nevermind that we're guests here. In a *Human* city."

She addresses me and her soldiers with a glare probably meant for them. Then she turns as Richard strides over. She glances at me, and then nods at

him. Yeah, that's a fair assessment. He *is* wearing armor and he looks like he's in charge.

"Are you the group known as the, uh... 'Americans'? Sorry we're late."

She pronounces the word oddly. Richard nods, extends a hand to shake. It's odd being called Americans, especially since America's a big place. Two continents, rather than one country. But hell, I guess America means the United States, not anywhere else.

Makes sense.

And I mean, what else were we supposed to call ourselves when we were asked who we were? Anyways, Richard is used to the awkwardness.

"Yes Ma'am. We're the Americans. And you are?"

She grasps his hand firmly. I note her claws, although Richard is wearing a gauntlet. She's a lizard! A giant lizard person! With a tail! And she's clearly a she. There's just something about her size, voice, and physique that tells me definitely that she's female while the soldier who nearly ran into me is male. She's humanoid enough in that respect.

"Cirille Bitterclaw, at your service. I'm the sorry [Commander] of this lot."

"Richard Davenport, Ma'am. A pleasure."

Cirille blinks a bit at being called 'Ma'am'. It's customary to call people 'Miss' or 'Mister' in this world unless they have a formal title, but Richard just can't get over calling people Sir or Ma'am no matter how many times he's corrected.

"You're our escort today?"

Emily comes over; Cirille nods briskly and indicates a large road her and the other lizards just walked down.

“That’s right, Miss. We’re your honorary guard. We’ll be walking you about two miles to the palace.”

“What? *All* of you?”

The lizard woman smiles wryly.

“That’s right. We’re dressed up for a little celebration, as you can see. There will be flowers, cheering—even if no one says who you are. There’re people in this city who’ll cheer a rolling barrel if it has an escort.”

I snort quietly. So much for our heroic return. What did Emily expect? We got kicked out of here the first time we arrived.

When we first came to Rhir, when we came to this world, we were welcomed with celebrations by the King himself and all the court. We were feasted, given parades...until they realized we weren’t actual heroes, but lost kids who couldn’t swing a sword properly. Then they shipped us out to die.

They brought us back because some of us proved we could fight.

And some of us slaughtered a bunch of Demons. Let’s not forget that.

...But I guess they’re not rolling out the red carpet for us this time, unless these lizards are meant to be more important than Rhir’s soldiers? Nah.

Cirille says pretty much the same thing to Richard as her soldiers line up on either side of us, looking bored and disinterested.

“Us? We’re not locals, Miss. We’re one of the foreign companies sent here on duty to assist the Blighted King. Sometimes that means escorting people around. Every day. Not the bigwigs, though. Us being here means you’re important enough for an escort, but not enough for a full parade.

They'd give you an escort of their own [Knights] and so on if you were. We get stuck marching for the lesser dignitaries and officials. Shall we?"

Richard nods. Our group forms up more or less in a line, and I see Cynthia and some of the others staring nervously at the lizard soldiers on either side. Oh no. My stomach clenches. This better not be like the incident with the Selphid soldier.

Aaah! Zombie! Burn the unholy thing! Don't let it touch me! And then there was Emily washing her hands after shaking the soldier's hand in plain view. Good times. Who says racism is dead? Or is it speciesism?

Richard must be thinking the same thing. He coughs and addresses Cirille before she gives the order to march.

"Pardon me for bringing this up, Ma'am, but we've never actually met someone from your...species before. Are you a, uh, liz—"

The entire group of soldiers seems to *freeze* for a second. Cirille cuts Richard off before he can continue.

"We're *Drakes*, sir. Drakes. Different from Lizardfolk. Very different. If you haven't seen any of those b—those other soldiers from Baleros, I imagine it's an easy mistake to make. But we're different."

He nods, gingerly.

"My apologies, Miss Cirille."

"Taken. Let's move out, you lot! Slowly!"

And so we do. I linger near Richard, letting him do the talking as we march out of the plaza and down one of the big roads leading to the palace ahead. Sure enough, there are people waving and cheering as we go by. I'm more interested in the conversation, though.

“That’s right. I was assigned to Rhir with my company. We got the short straw, depending on how you look at it. All the other parts of our army were assigned to the front or to patrol various spots, but they needed someone to look shiny and didn’t want to waste their own soldiers on the job.”

“Oh? Is that normal?”

“Pretty much. Every nation has to send an army to support Rhir. If it were all-out war, I’d be under the command of an actual [General] and there would be at least two Drake armies here. But it’s not, so our lot gets to patrol and go claw-to-claw with those Demon bastards on the front for fun. It’s part of the old treaties, you know.”

Richard nods. He knows, and I do too. Rhir is at war. It has been for thousands of years, apparently. Right now, the Blighted King, the sole ruler of the continent, is battling the Demon King, who is the leader of...the continent. But of Demons and monsters, so apparently he’s not acknowledged as an actual king.

Bit weird, that. Why call him a king, then?

Anyways, the Demons and monsters that come from the corrupted part of the continent are so dangerous that four walls were built to hold them back, and there’s almost always fighting somewhere or other. The Blighted Kingdom gets aid from the rest of the world to hold the Demons back, apparently in the form of soldiers as well.

I eye Cirille. She’s a Drake? Does that mean she’s related to Dragons as opposed to...well, whatever a Lizardperson is related to? Unlike the rest of her soldiers, her armor is open at the back to let two vestigial wings out. They’re folded up neatly and rather small. She notices me looking and smiles. Toothily.

“Oldblood. Don’t mind the wings; they’re for show. I can’t get off the ground, but apparently that means I’m special enough to get chosen for a

year's service in this hellhole."

"Oh. Uh. I'm Tom."

"Pleased. I don't get to talk to the people I'm marching with that often. Usually they're too important. You a warrior?"

"Nope. Not me. I—no."

She blinks at me.

"Alright, then."

Smooth, Tom. Nice going. The one person who thinks you're not crazy and you tip her off in five seconds. Is that a Skill, too?

I hate the voice in my head.

Talking to voices, Tom. First sign of madness.

But I'm not insane. I'm not. The voice is...a voice. A figment of my imagination. Nothing more.

Only an insane person would have to tell himself he's sane.

"Or a really sane person would say that. Because only sane people check to make sure they're not insane."

"What did you say, Tom?"

Ahead of me, Emily stops waving, looking slightly—I stop muttering under my breath and try to smile at her. Not hugely, not creepily wide or anything else like that. A small, slight smile.

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

Aha. Look at her face. She doesn't think that's normal!

Everyone talks to themselves. Introverts probably do it more than extroverts, and Emily's definitely the latter. But everyone does do it. That

doesn't make me any crazier for acknowledging that.

So you say. Keep telling yourself that.

Shut up, me.

Time to explain again. Hi, I'm Tom.

You did that already.

Shut up, shut *up!* I'm Tom. And I'm not insane. I can't be. I just...it's not a voice in my head. Or rather, it's just another part of me. That's the trick, you see? I have to understand that. If I don't, I'm schizophrenic, or paranoid.

Or insane.

But the voice is me. It's a bad joke, as if I'm playing devil's advocate with everything I do. It's overthinking things, putting words to an imaginary personality. But there's only me in here.

Keep telling yourself that. Did I say that already?

Isn't it fun? I sigh and slap myself, which makes one of the Drake [Soldiers] walking with me eye me oddly. I ignore him.

If it's not a voice in my head, then what? I think about that every day. If it's not a voice...

It started the day after the others found me surrounded by Demon corpses, drenched in blood, laughing my head off and nearly dying of blood loss. I swore I'd never be a [Clown] again, never fight. Not when I saw and remembered what I'd done. I let the crazy out. *I* went insane. And it's been my choice to not do it again. Because it is me that did all those terrible things, that slaughtered those soldiers. Not anyone else.

Not a monster, you mean.

Exactly. It's me. Not anything else. And because I know that, I won't go crazy.

Unless you already are. Keep telling yourself I'm just a voice, Tom. But we both know the truth. You're crazy. And the smile you show everyone else, the little act? It's wearing thin, day after day. You lost it the day Wilen died. And all your 'friends' are waiting for the day you snap again.

Including me.

I don't see much of the city during the march. I'm busy humming loudly in my head. But I do catch up with Cirille as she tells Richard about some of the capital's highlights.

"If you've got time, head down towards the port area. That's where most of us foreigners hang out off-duty. The Balerosian and Chandrarian companies are already headed towards the Fourth Wall, and I don't envy them, but the Terandrians still have a detachment hanging about."

"Terandrians?"

"Humans like you. Sorry, I assumed—are you from Baleros or Chandrar, then?"

"No, we're from further away than that."

"Really? Where, if you don't mind me asking?"

I don't get to hear how Richard talks his way out of this one. I hear a shout as we pass through another set of gates, from up ahead. Cirille, Richard, and I step forwards quickly and see Cynthia running backwards, face white and pale.

“A Demon!”

Richard and I instantly freeze. My heart begins to pound. A Demon? Here? In the city? It can't be. But Richard's hand is already on his sword and my own demon begins whispering in my head. Yet it's Cirille who doesn't panic. She grips Richard before he can draw his blade.

“Hold up. I think I know what the problem is.”

She leads quickly past the suddenly wary Drakes, and we pass by a stretch of...what I can only call displays of enemy prisoners. There are cages, small, cramped, and hung from massive chains or put on platforms for passersby to stare at. And they hold something to remind the people living in the city who to hate.

Demons.

They have horns, dark skin which is purple in many cases, but their appearances can be as mutated and different depending on which Demon it is. Some might pass for Human...if you ignore a third eye or extra limb. But they are Demons, sworn to kill all the people of Rhir.

And one is sitting in an iron cage ahead of us. He's the only one; the other cages are empty, although I can see bloodstains dried in several. Not many Demons get captured alive, apparently. And this one's just sitting there, a good distance away from our procession. Only Cynthia would freak out that much over seeing one, but then, no one in our group is happy to see them.

They slaughtered us. Over two thirds of our groups died in one night when we were sent to the front lines. Even seeing one now makes me afraid. But he is behind bars.

“It's just one Demon, Cynthia. Don't scream.”

Richard admonishes Cynthia, who's gone into hysterics. Behind us, one of the Drakes mutters something uncomplimentary about Humans. Cirille shuts him up. I keep staring.

This Demon has bright yellow eyes, two curved horns like a ram, and fur. Normal, human feet, though, which *is* odd. Four toes, four fingers. He's...weird.

“Stay back. That's one of the captives they just brought in. A Fearless.”

Cirille orders her soldiers and the rest of us on, but she stays, eyeing the Demon in the cage. I look at her. Some of the crowd that was cheering our passing has broken away and is jeering and shouting at him. They look angry. Some have rocks.

“A Fearless? Why is he here?”

The Drake shrugs.

“Search me. It's one of the things you Humans do. Sorry, I mean, the people of the Blighted Kingdom do. They like reminding themselves what the enemy looks like, I guess. Drakes, we just kill our enemies. But it's worth memorizing these guys. Know what a Fearless is?”

“No.”

One of the people in front, a young woman, hurls a stone. It glances off the bars of the cage. A bad throw. But more start throwing stones. The Fearless sits there, not moving an inch. A rock strikes his shoulder, drawing a bit of blood. The crowd cheers. But the Demon doesn't look afraid. Not at all. A look of irritation flashes over his face and he covers his face with one hand.

“Fearless are a type of Demon. They have a class. Well, I say class, but it's more like an addition to their normal class. [Fearless Warrior], [Fearless

Mage], get it? And the class does exactly what you'd think. They can't feel fear. Not at all."

I stare at the Demon. He's got scars all over his body, beneath the fur. From the look of it, he's been stoned before. Badly. But when the hail of rocks subsides a bit, he lowers his hand and stares around, and his eyes do indeed contain no fear.

That makes the crowd lose some of their rage. If the Demon was defiant, or raging at them, they might have kept going. But this Fearless... it's one thing to master your fear. But another to have none. It's...unnatural.

I can see it in the way the Demon moves, the way he looks around. He's wary of the rocks, of being blinded or hurt. He doesn't like the pain. But he doesn't fear it either. And he doesn't fear death. The Fearless stares around, watchful, calculating.

Then he looks at me. He stares at me and Cirille. She glares at him. I shudder and look away. We walk away as the Fearless sits in his cage, rejoining the procession.

You and he are the same. Don't deny it.

Ignore the voice. I turn to Cirille as we catch up with the others. Richard's ahead, trying to get Cynthia to calm down before she has a panic attack.

"So that's a type of Demon? There are lots of them like him?"

"Dead gods, I hope not."

Cirille shudders, her tail twitching as she walks briskly ahead of me.

"They're more like shock troopers. Each one's a dangerous fighter who's not afraid to die, and they'll charge through killing grounds if they have to. They're not idiots, but they're willing to die to take you with them.

The Demon King uses them when he wants to win. I don't know how many people that one killed, but I'd rather see him dead than in a cage."

We pass by a street that looks like it leads to some kind of fantastical bazaar, and then one devoted entirely to food. I stare at a cut of dark grey meat and point it out to Cirille. She looks sideways at it and one of the soldiers at the back of the parade mutters. She shakes her head.

"Demon meat."

"Demon—"

I break off, not wanting to startle my companions ahead of me. Cirille looks uneasy and shakes her head before lowering her voice.

"They eat Demons here. I don't like it, but that's how it works. See the fellow buying? That's one of the [Flesh Reapers]. Don't bother them."

I see a hooded figure with long, *long* arms reaching for a dripping package from the stony-faced [Butcher].

Mm. Tasty. Try some. I'm sure you could get a sample.

I shudder and hurry on.

In the end, our parade reaches the gates of the palace without another incident. I pretty much tune out the cheering. It might be meant for me, but I can't find any pleasure in it.

Would it help if they were screaming?

And I'm—distracted. I always am. Cirille sees us off at the gates as the Drake [Soldiers] stand at attention. One of them yawns widely until the guy next to her elbows her in the side.

"Here we are. I might see you inside at the banquet tonight. Anyone with any kind of nobility or a title gets invited. Look for the Drakes if you want to find me."

She nods, and Richard shakes her hand again. She walks past me, and the Drakes depart. The rest of us stare up at the gate. It's massive, and beyond it, a huge courtyard leads up to the palace of the Blighted King. A staircase stretches from the courtyard to the palace gates, and the citadel rises higher, so high it feels like it's touching the clouds.

We stayed here, once. We will again. This time, I wonder if we're wiser, or if the Blighted King will see more of what he wants in us. I don't know. And I am afraid.

He scares me. Being here scares me. But what scares me most is the little voice I can't get rid of. It whispers as we walk through the gates.

Welcome home.

His name is Nereshal. With a name like that, he should be tall, lean, with a strong face, perhaps an Egyptian-style nose, long and sharp, and piercing features. He's not. Instead, he's rather short, slightly overweight, although not as heavy as I am, and his nose isn't nearly that pronounced.

But his eyes are piercing. They have the cold, detached look I've seen before, in the eyes of the soldiers escorting us. The eyes of someone who's seen war. And he wears dark grey robes lined with silver that don't quite hide the scars on his arms and left hand.

He lectures us as he leads us through the palace on a tour.

"You may recall the rules for staying here from your previous visits, but it is my duty to remind you of the laws of the Kingdom. Specifically, about magic."

We pass by countless rooms, meant for sleeping, eating, training, planning battle, or just as diversions. Rooms filled with treasures, a room full of huge, floor-to-wall mirrors without a single flaw, a room filled with bright lights that hover around randomly—countless wonders, treasures of the Blighted King. His palace is rich, even if the people who live on the edges of his Kingdom can barely eat.

We pass all of it by as Nereshal lectures us. He points to a glowing light the size of my head, placed just above head height in the corridor we're walking down. Without it, the enclosed palace would be dark as night. There are few windows, and the passageways throughout the place are a labyrinth unto themselves, especially given how large the palace is. It could hold several lesser castles easily.

“Mage lights. By law, no outdoor area in Paranfer may be dark at night. To prevent assassins and spies from entering the city as well as crime. That goes for within the palace as well. They are impossible to disrupt by accident, but note that tampering with them is a crime.”

“Like failing to present arms when ordered, obeying a guard, yeah, yeah, what's *not* a crime around here?”

Nereshal stops abruptly and turns to Eddy. I groan and Richard glares at him. Eddy raises his hands.

“What? I'm just saying.”

He never knows when to shut up. Now Nereshal stares at him, and Eddy's grin slips a bit.

“Okay, it's serious.”

“You do not seem to understand that. You are guests of His Majesty, not arrogant [Princes]. You do not have the authority to order around servants. And I am no servant.”

“I just—”

“Be silent.”

Nereshal’s hand reaches out. He doesn’t tap Eddy, but whatever Eddy was about to say is cut off. His mouth gapes open and his eyes widen. He tries to speak, I know he does. His mouth begins to close, incredibly slowly. Panicked, Eddy’s hands feel at his mouth, quickly searching around his face.

“What did you do to him?”

Richard interposes himself between Nereshal and Eddy, looking concerned and angry. The [Mage] glances at Richard.

“I slowed the passage of time around his mouth. It will wear off. And he will learn to mind his manners here.”

There’s a pause as everyone stares at him. Vincent’s voice rises in disbelief.

“You’re a *time mage*?”

“I thought time magic was impossible!”

Emily, our highest-level [Mage], stares at Nereshal. So do I. I don’t remember him from our first time here, but then, it was a blur to me. Nereshal nods coldly.

“Lesser [Mages] may believe so. But the magic of time is another form of power, and the Blighted Kingdom demands all forms of magic in its defense.”

“What can you do, if you don’t mind me asking?”

Richard looks at Nereshal, once it becomes clear that Eddy’s mouth is the only thing affected. The [Mage] strides onwards, speaking quickly and

precisely.

“I can speed up a flight of arrows or slow an enemy’s charge. I can hasten a weather front moving in, or slow the collapse of a wall. But I remain here for my most important duty.”

“Which is?”

He glances over his shoulder with those cold eyes.

“Preventing the aging of the Blighted King. So he may rule a month, a year, a decade longer. Until I am released from my duties here, I also act as his steward. Take heed of my warnings. If you are found violating any of the laws, the guards who patrol may not wait for explanations. And if you survive that, I will administer a fitting punishment.”

No one has much to say about that. I glance around the group. I’m at the back, since everyone else gets nervous when they stand next to me. We’re definitely not getting treated like we did before. Which might be a good thing.

“Are there any other rules we might break by accident, Sir?”

Richard speaks to Nereshal as he leads us to our rooms, a series of individual bedrooms in a far wing of the palace. The [Mage] considers this.

“I note that two of you seem to have become decent [Mages] in the time since your last stay here. Do any of you know any form of teleportation spell? I caution you not to try casting the spell while staying here.”

“No. No one knows the spell. Why?”

Nereshal gestures to one of the walls. In parts of the castle, the stones are rough and thick, and the corridors narrow. In others, they’re wide open and sweeping, a sign of polished craftsmanship. But everywhere I can feel a faint tingle that makes me feel as though there’s serious magic here.

Or it's just in your head.

“Teleportation magic is strictly prohibited around the castle. It is also impossible. An enchantment prohibits teleportation magic of any kind around the castle and city itself. I doubt there are many rules you will break by accident, but remember what I have said.”

He eyes Eddy and his fingers twitch. Eddy gasps as his jaw finally closes, and he keeps his mouth shut, looking pale. The [Mage] turns towards Richard.

“Your presence is requested at tonight’s feast. Clothing will be sent to your rooms. There will be a selection. Shortly thereafter, servants will appear to guide you to the banquet hall.”

“Right.”

Richard hesitates. He looks at Nereshal.

“Should we...prepare? Will we be expected to bow, or...?”

“Deference is expected. Etiquette is not. Your last visit made that clear. However, you may be expected to stand before His Majesty, in which case you will speak with respect.”

“What does he—what does His Majesty want with us?”

“To appraise your worth.”

A single line, cold and indelicate as the winter we lived through. The [Mage] looks at Richard, and then at Emily.

“I am told two of your number reached Level 30. That is a marker of respect in our kingdom, and you will be accorded its due so long as you protect the realm. You have changed since you were ordered to the front. That is good. As for the other reason why His Majesty ordered your return...”

His eyes linger on me. I feel a pang of fear in my chest.

“His Majesty is interested in confirming the rumors of your success for his own eyes. I trust he will not be disappointed.”

His eyes stare right through me. I look away, as the whispering in my head grows louder. The Blighted King knows about me? Of course he does. And he’s expecting a hero. Or maybe just a warrior.

I think he’ll be disappointed. I hope he will be.

The banquet is the kind of thing you’d see in a fantasy movie. Big. Magical. And in a room so large and ornate, it can hold a thousand or more diners. Thousands? I’m no good with counting.

And there’s so much to see! Rich nobles sit at long tables, talking with foreign dignitaries of various species. I can see Drakes, the similar yet very different Lizardfolk, strange armored people whose heads seemed to detach like the Headless Horseman...creatures I recognize, like Centaurs and Minotaurs. There’s a Minotaur in a *suit*, chatting with some huge, furry creature that reminds me a bit of Chewbacca crossed with a dog. A Gnoll, apparently.

Some sit, others stand and talk, like they’re at a cocktail party for the rich and powerful. Wait, that’s what this is, isn’t it? There’s music, entertainment for the kids from mages and more conventional sources—even a guy in a bright outfit, doing pratfalls to amuse a cluster of children. They’re all dressed like royalty.

Especially the royalty. The Blighted King and his Queen sit at one end of the room, at a table with a chair that’s practically a throne in itself. But it

isn't the throne; I've seen the throne and that thing is scary. This chair is merely ornate and golden.

The room hums with energy, and projects the kind of richness and power that makes me tremble in my boots. I don't belong here. Not me, a kid born of a working class family. But I tremble for other reasons when I look at the Blighted King from afar.

"You may conduct your affairs for the feast as you wish. His Majesty only requests that you stay within his presence until you are summoned or given leave to go."

One of the lesser [Chamberlains] serving underneath Nereshal speaks to our stunned group. We, the children from another world, stare at him, and then hesitantly step into the room. We've been here before. We were feasted at the Blighted King's own table, once. But that was a lifetime ago, when the world was still magical.

When we were still all [Heroes]. I'm not. I gave it up and lost the class when I refused to fight, to answer the people's calls. Richard still has it. So does Emily and a few others. But they're not real heroes.

Some of the warriors sitting at the table look like heroes, though. They wear shining armor, and those who are dressed for pleasure rather than war still move with unnatural grace. The Blighted King has [Knights] and champions of countless classes of his own. I see Richard looking nervous. He was allowed to keep his sword—a mark of respect, I guess, but I doubt he'd draw it under any situation.

There are guards at the Blighted King's table, watchful figures, not all of whom carry swords. Several of them glanced at us when we were announced. Several of them glanced at *me*.

So did the King. It was just a flick of the eyes before he turned away, but it confirmed what we all knew. He'll want to speak with us. The thought

makes some, like Cynthia, afraid to enter the room. Others, like Richard, are made of sterner stuff.

“Come on, let’s join the feast.”

He says it, but no one moves. The [Chamberlain] coughs gently. But no one wants to walk out into that magnificent display and attract any attention to themselves.

I could. Perhaps. But the urging in my mind might make that a bad idea. Part of me wants to stride out there, shout, laugh, and cartwheel if I can even pull that off, and make a spectacle. To *clown* in short. To lose control.

Make them laugh, Tom. Let go for a second. You know you want to.

Nope. I’m not making the first move. But someone has to. A woman dressed all in red sweeps by our group, glass in hand. She looks... melancholy. And determined to hide it. She has a presence that makes half the guys and girls in our group go weak at the knees. Mine are fine.

You’d go weak at the knees if she stabbed you. Or you stabbed her.

You’d never see the blood, as bright as her gown is. I bite the inside of my lip. Emily squeaks.

“Who is *that*?”

The [Chamberlain], looking put upon, gently prods Vincent forwards a bit and speaks softly.

“That is [Lady] Theras. If you would like to enter and speak with her, please understand she is in mourning, hence the red dress.”

“Red? Why, what does that mean?”

Everyone looks at the [Chamberlain]. He pauses awkwardly, clearly not wanting to say, and then realizes he has to. He clears his throat again.

“Miscarriage. [Lady] Theras and her sister, the [Lady] Zekyria, both lost their children unexpectedly three months ago. They have been in mourning ever since.”

“Oh.”

Instantly, most of us shuffled our feet and looked at our dress shoes. Eddy chooses this moment to speak. He’d been doing great after meeting Nereshal.

“So they wear red if they’re in mourning. After three months?”

“This is correct. Sir.”

“Weird.”

“What’s *weird* about that, Eddy?”

Emily and a few girls turn to stare at Eddy. He grimaces.

“It’s just that I didn’t think they’d be so open about it, you know? And it’s been three months...”

“So? What’s wrong with that? Why can’t she be open about it?”

Chole glares at him. Eddy shrugs helplessly. He seems to realize he’s put his foot in it again.

“I dunno. It’s weird, right?”

He looks around. I try not to meet his eye.

“It’s not her fault.”

He shrinks back a bit from Chole’s glare.

“Well, yeah, but...”

He doesn't have more than that. Uncomfortable, he looks away. I mentally shake my head. Where were you going with that one, Eddy?

He must not like dead babies. At least they're quieter than live ones, right?

After another second, Chole turns away from Eddy and walks over to [Lady] Theras. She starts talking to the woman, and the surprised older lady sets down her drink to talk with her. That's the cue for our group to break up.

We enter the banquet. And it swallows us. In a few minutes, I find myself at a table. We're sitting with Cirille, since she's the only one we recognized. She and a couple of Drakes seem only too happy to have company to talk to. And there's quite a bit of food for me to distract myself by eating.

Jellied fruits, sweet breads, cuts of meat dripping with blood and finely-grilled vegetables of every shape and color...the wrong thing for anyone on a diet. Since I've lost at least thirty pounds from not wanting to eat, I don't care and dig in anyways. Beside me, Cirille is talking to Keith about something called the Walled Cities, and a problem with some species called the Antinium. And apparently there's a problem with a...Goblin Lord?

I'm only half listening. Food is one of the things that usually grants me a reprieve, but I'm—struggling. With myself. I have a selection of spoons to use, and one of them, one with an edged front, like a spork, has caught my eye.

Go on. Pick up the spoon.

I stare at it. I want to. I can see myself picking up the spoon, and then gouging Keith's eye out. Or my own. A spoon. What a convenient weapon. But everything's convenient when you use it right.

Wrong. Use it wrong. It's just a thought.

Take it.

I stare at my right hand. It doesn't move. I deliberately raise it, take the spoon, and dip it into my soup. I chose soup to start with. It's delicious. I barely taste it.

You are insane.

“Mnot.”

“What, Tom?”

Keith looks over. He sat himself so that Cirille was between him and me. I shake my head and he looks...nervous. That annoys me.

All of the guys and girls can't stand to be around me anymore. Not after the village. I know what they saw. Of course I do! But can't they pretend? Can't they—at least Richard tries. The rest jump if I so much as sneeze. Cynthia won't be in the same room with me.

A [Clown]. I chose the class on a lark, because I thought—

I thought this might happen. But I didn't expect it to happen like this. I thought I might be able to get powers.

You wanted to be an insane clown and didn't want the insanity? Hah! That is a good joke. Now stab Keith in his treacherous little eye. Go on. You picked up the spoon, didn't you?

God, maybe I *am* insane. I keep having the same thoughts, over and over in my head. Isn't that the first sign of insanity?

That's not insanity, you idiot.

Yes it is. Einstein said that. I think.

Across the table, Richard is talking with Emily. She's flirting. I think he might be as well. Or perhaps he's oblivious. They're a couple, at least in

some sense of the word, but it's not official. If there is an official. I don't think they've had sex yet. News would spread quickly in our tight-knit circle.

Lonely Tom. Why don't you try your luck? I'm sure Emily would come to love you. If you held a knife to her throat. Why bother with that? Just kill her. Throw the spoon.

[Unerring Throw]. How hard could I toss it?

Just a thought. They're just...thoughts. They pass by, and it doesn't mean I'll act on them. But does everyone have these murderous ideas? I have to distract myself. I push the bowl back and put the spoon in it, probably committing a major breach of etiquette.

“Hey, so what's this I'm hearing about a war with the Goblins?”

Cirille turns towards me. Across from her, a Drake with red scales slams his fist onto the table, making my bowl of soup jump.

“It's a crime, that's what! Garusa Weatherfur and Thrissiam Blackwing are *dead*! Two of our finest [Generals] and over twenty thousand good Gnolls and Drakes, gone, and for what? Because those bickering bastards couldn't field a larger army? We could have sent three times that number! And I heard that vital intelligence wasn't even passed on to them! The Goblin Lord uses *undead*, and no one thought to pass off that tidbit to either [General]! Some [Mage] bastard or low-level [Scribe] thought it wasn't important information when it *came from Zel Shivertail himself*!”

He grabs a goblet and drains it, ignoring the looks he is getting from further up and down the table. The Drake raises his voice, cutting above the local babble of voices.

“It's bloody infighting that's killing us, when we should be cutting the Goblin Lord off at the knees and then banding together against those blasted

Humans—not you lot, the ones from the north—or the Antinium! We don't have time to spend infighting. Hah, I'm beginning to see why Shivertail doesn't spend his time in politics if all the eggheads back home can't defeat a damn Goblin!"

His companions try to placate the angry Drake. I'm pleased. This is a good distraction.

"It sounds like they're not that competent."

"You're telling me?"

The Drake turns one bloodshot eye to me. I can sense his tail lashing the ground angrily underneath the table.

"Every year we send an army to pound the Humans, and every year they send one down to the Bloodfields. We tear each other apart, killing thousands like clockwork, then march on back and say what a glorious victory we had! On both sides! Either invade and start tearing down cities or make peace already! Don't waste our soldiers' lives when there's real wars to be fought!"

His speech gets voices of approval from some of the other Drakes at the table. Cirille rolls her eyes and twitches her wings as if she's heard the same griping many times before. I nod, trying to keep the Drake talking. It slips out before I can help it.

"Yeah, exactly. That's insane. Insanity's doing the same thing over and over again and expecting different results, right? That's the definition of it, anyways."

I freeze. I didn't mean to ask. It was just a thought in my head! I sense every head, every person from my world, stop talking and turn to look at me. They stare. There's fear in some eyes.

"Yeah, well you'd know, right Tom?"

Eddy says that. Good old Eddy, breaking the sudden silence. The others laugh, a bit too loudly. Cirille rolls her eyes and flicks her tail.

“Tell that to my superiors. They’re happy enough to send a few thousand soldiers over here to get combat experience, never mind the losses.”

“That’s different. That’s...that’s important. This war has to be won. Can’t expect to make peace with Demons. Not those bastards. Lost a detachment to the Fearless the other day. Crazy bastards ran right onto my [Pikemen].”

The Drake, who’d been so angry, slumps into his chair morosely. Talk turns elsewhere. I relax a bit, only to shoot up when I sense Keith poking me. I turn.

“What?”

“Tom, that’s just a myth. Einstein never said that.”

“Said? Said what?”

“Insanity. You know, doing the same thing over and over? That’s not the actual definition, you know.”

My blood runs cold.

“What? No, it is.”

He shakes his head.

“People assume Einstein said it, but that’s just a myth. Trust me, my professor loved to talk about laws. Insanity isn’t a real medical condition. It’s a legal term. It means...well, it’s a defense people used. If you’re insane you can’t be held responsible for breaking the law. Medically, it doesn’t really exist anymore. It doesn’t make sense.”

That's not the definition. I was wrong. And he—I—

I was wrong.

Keith nods towards me, helpful, oblivious. I stare at him with a grin frozen on my face until I realize what I'm doing. I turn back, staring at my cooled bowl of soup and not seeing it. Inside my chest, my heart's suddenly beating all too fast.

How did he know? No—I must have known. It's a coincidence, that's all. I must have known and subconsciously—

It's me in here. Just me. And the voice is just a voice.

Are you crazy? Or am I real? Am I something else? How would I know that, Tom? Who am I?

Who are you?

I sit in my chair, sit as the world greys out around me. It must be me. It *has* to be me. I went crazy back then and I might be crazy now. But I can't let it be anyone else. Even if it is. Because if I don't take responsibility for my actions, I really will go crazy. I'll use that as an excuse. It's always been me. If it's not—

Then who's in here with me?

“Tom? *Tom!*”

Someone's hissing at me, shaking me. I look up. I was sitting for so long that I didn't notice the room go silent. I didn't hear, and I didn't realize everyone around me was standing up. I look around and see Richard shaking my shoulder, face pale.

I look up, and at the head of the room, the Blighted King is on his feet. He is staring towards our table, towards us. And his eyes are locked on me.

Slowly, I rise. By his side the [Chronomancer], the mage Nereshal, beckons. We slowly leave our table and file towards the Blighted King. I stare at him.

I am afraid. But not of him. I break out into a cold sweat as I approach him, one of the most powerful men in the world, the one who summoned us here. Not because of his presence, not because of the armed guards who stand next to him, or his stare that weighs us like ants. I do not fear him.

But there is someone laughing in my head. And I am terribly afraid that person isn't me.

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The Blighted King has a presence. It weighs down on me as I walk forwards. The silent feasting hall is too long, and the few of us have to walk past the watching guests, hearts pounding.

And as we approach the front of the room, I feel it. The King sits at his table, next to a tall woman who dwarfs him with her stature. But he is like a rock, too heavy. His very existence weighs us down, makes me feel—

Gassy?

I can remember the first time I stood in front of him. Then, it was like being crushed as he looked at us. Now, it is different.

Around me, the others shudder. I see Emily's face go pale, Keith start sweating, Cynthia's eyes roll wildly in her head, and Richard clench his jaw. They are being crushed. I walk, feeling my shoulders ache. It's... heavy.

That's all.

We stop, in a ragged line along the steps leading up to the raised area where he is seated. The King looks down at us. We meet again.

There is no love in his gaze, no sense of familiarity. He weighs us with eyes that seem like scales, measuring our worth. Most of us stare at our feet, or at some other part of the room. Some are shaking. I look at the Blighted King. I can't be afraid of him. Not like I was.

Does that make me strange? I'm certainly alone from the others. I can feel it, but I can't help it. Fear's another one of those things I lost. I'm not

afraid of people with swords. I'm not happy about being stabbed, but they can't scare me.

I scare me.

“So. The heroes of prophecy return. Diminished.”

The Blighted King speaks at last. His voice echoes through the chamber. It's not grand. It's not particularly wise. It's just an old man's voice, tired. I stare at him and see few grey hairs in his beard. But he is old. He sounds like it. I wonder how long Nereshal has been keeping him young.

Here sits a monster. Ageless. And here stands a monster. Can he see it in you, Tom? Or is this King as worthless as the land he rules?

The King's eyes flick towards me for a second, and then towards Richard and Emily.

“We have been told that two of your number have reached Level 30. A commendable achievement in such a short time.”

“Miraculous.”

The whisper comes from the Blighted Queen. She's younger than the King, but her towering height makes her seem older. I stare at her. She can't be more than thirty, while he...

“But so many have been lost. We sent over sixty of you to do battle against the Demons. Now less than a third remain.”

“That wasn't our fault! We told you, we're not warriors. We—”

Emily raises her voice and chokes as the Blighted King's gaze falls on her. He nods, once.

“So you have said. But some of you are warriors. The rest have seen the threat which imperils our nation. Nay, the very world itself. Would you hide

behind walls my people have died for, deny your purpose still?”

“Not me. I’ll fight. But we can’t all be held to the same standard, Your Majesty.”

This time it’s Richard who speaks. The Blighted King weighs his words and nods.

“One has reached Level 30 in three months. A [Knight] he stands, sworn against darkness. Yet no [Lord] or [Lady] has given him a title. Another, a [Mage] of water, has taught herself. Miraculous feats, as our lady says.”

The Blighted King looks across our group, at frightened faces. He pauses.

“You will have a place in our halls, and your companions’ food and my protection so long as you hold back the scourge of darkness. But we have heard of one more. A champion who defended our people. A warrior who slew a Demon raiding party single-handed.”

His eyes move to me. I feel a chill.

“You. Step forwards.”

I can see Richard and Emily both staring at me, worried, out of the corners of their eyes. I take a step forwards and sense the eyes of everyone in the hall on me. Oh boy.

Want me to tell them a joke? How about a magic trick?

My lips twitch. I try not to smile. I don’t feel afraid. Rather, in this moment, as the Blighted King stares at me, some strange, perverse side of me wants to fart, or laugh. He’s so serious. Everyone is. They hang on his words. Whereas I—

Get the joke.

The hilarity vanishes. I feel cold. No, it's not funny. The Blighted King certainly doesn't find me amusing. He frowns.

"We recall thee from before. Who art thou? What is your class? [Warrior]? [Mage]? [Rogue]?"

"None of those, Your Majesty. I'm—I'm a [Clown]. Not a fighter, actually."

He stares at me. I hear Cynthia begin to giggle, a mad, hysterical cackle which cuts off quickly. The King looks confused.

"What class is this?"

"One from our world, Your Highness. Tom is an—an entertainer. Someone who makes people laugh. Clowns aren't fighters. They're..."

Emily trails off, unable to explain what I am. The King exchanges a slow glance with his Queen. I can sense people's eyes fixed on my back. I know I look ordinary. I don't have my face paint on, or a rubber nose or the oversized shoes I made. I'm not juggling or wearing a silly grin. I have nothing to prove I have a funny class in any way.

You have me. You always have me.

"An entertainer? How did you slay a war band of Demons, then? Speak."

He looks at me and I feel heavier. That's all. And perhaps it's the devil in my chest, but I don't want to answer. So I shrug.

"Luck, I guess. Your Majesty. I don't know how exactly. But that's what us summoned heroes are supposed to do, right? I got...lucky. But I am no warrior. Sorry about that."

I hear a hiss and see Richard wince. The Blighted King fixes me with a look that tells me he's annoyed.

“So you claim. But if thou art an entertainer, prove it.”

“What?”

He leans back in his chair that’s like and unlike a throne and gestures.

“Perform, [Clown]. Show the court the tricks of your profession. Make us laugh.”

Oh boy. Now everyone’s staring at me, and I suddenly find myself on the spot. I glance around uncertainly and see Richard giving me a pale-faced look. Emily’s standing back and half of the others are trying to pretend they don’t know me.

I don’t have my makeup, my props—but I can tell there’s no point protesting or making excuses. So I sigh and flick my wrist. A bright red ball, stuffed with dried beans to make it round, appears in my hand. I hear a murmur and someone at the head table sits up.

My heart isn’t pounding. I feel embarrassed and sure I’m about to make an idiot out of myself, but I’m not afraid. Why? Why not?

No, this is normal. It’s because I’ve seen worse than this. Far worse. What’s a few minutes of humiliation?

I hold the red ball up, and I sense a thousand pairs of eyes on me. Now I do smile, at the ludicrous nature of this. I’m no famous performer. I’m self-taught, and badly at that! I couldn’t make a bunch of village kids laugh. But here I am, about to perform before the Blighted King. Okay, that *is* funny.

Willen, this is for you. Red ball in hand, I flick my other hand and a blue one appears. I hear a soft gasp, from the Blighted King’s table, but nowhere else.

That’s right. I can make things appear and disappear at will. I can also make objects vanish, pull the old ‘coin behind the ear’ trick with objects too

large to hide. Because I have a pocket space.

It's two Skills, actually. [Sleight of Hand] and [Trick Space]. One allows me to do stupid tricks like you'd see card magicians do if I had a deck of cards, and the other gives me an invisible space around my body I can pull objects out of and put into. I keep three balls there. The third comes out, yellow and worn.

A second gasp. Who's making that sound? For the first time I wrench my gaze away from the Blighted King and to his left. I see a young woman, not more than...sixteen perhaps, sitting tall at his side, wearing a sparkling circlet made of dark metal. And sitting next to her, on a cushion to let her actually reach her plate on the table—

A young girl. A [Princess], no doubt. Her dress is bright green and white, and she's very pretty in that way kids are. Her eyes are wide as they fix on the balls in my hand. A child. I saw her laughing at the guy doing pratfalls earlier. I give her a small bow. Hope this entertains you at least, kid.

It won't. You suck.

Shut up. I begin tossing the balls up in the air, juggling them quickly. It's hard to do three balls at once. I know that tells you how much I suck, but I had to practice a long time to get to that level. [Sleight of Hand] doesn't work with juggling and I don't have a Skill.

I really need one. At least [Unerring Throw] lets me decide where the balls come down. Hey, I might be able to do four balls this way! Too bad I don't *have* four balls.

The room watches me juggle, and I see the young [Princess] brighten and nearly clap her hands as I start juggling the balls high into the air. The older girl, another [Princess] probably, stops her. Everyone watches as I juggle.

And watches.

And watches...

After a few seconds they realize that's all I'm going to do. Yes, that's right. I can feel the Blighted King's gaze boring into me. What? Do you want me to do pins? I can juggle pins too, but my act has been pratfalls, juggling, and terrible jokes. And I think that if I tried to trip over his table, I'd be skewered.

So I'm giving him a terrible performance. I was planning on just juggling until he stopped me, but then it happens. I hear a sound.

“♪Doo doo doodle do do doo doo doot~♪”

Oh god. The *music*. It's been too long since I heard it play. I could live for the rest of my life without it. I sense a shift when it goes off, and hear a muffled sound from the others standing around me. The rest of the room just stares, uncomprehending.

Clown music. Silly, stupid. It fills the grand room, playing stupidly. Only with a twist. There's laughter, too. Someone's laughing.

And it's not anyone in this room. I nearly drop a ball, making it vanish before tossing it back up in the air as the laughter plays with the music. There's a spectral audience now, laughing voices, as if I really am at a circus.

That's not what scares me, though. I hear one of the voices laughing. And it's my own. It laughs and laughs, until I stop juggling.

This time, the silence is different. I make all three balls vanish and bow silently. The [Princess] looks vaguely entertained. Everyone else does not. But the music. Ah, the music. I look sideways and see Richard staring at me with a pale face.

Everyone, all of the other young men and women from my world, are giving me the same look. They remember. And the music scares them.

That doesn't escape the attention of the Blighted King. He stares at me, and then at the others. How much does he actually know about what I did? He waits, until he realizes I'm not doing anything else.

"Continue, [Clown]."

"Sorry. That's all I've got."

"That?"

His eyebrows raise. He looks incredulous. I nod, waiting for him to tell me I'm a fraud or whatever. I don't want to hear that sound ever again. But then someone else bellows into the silence.

"Ridiculous!"

The word makes me jump. I see Richard jump, Emily turn white—Cynthia screams, predictably. A flash of color brushes against me to my left, and someone pushes me out of the way.

Not roughly, not hard, but with force, so I go sprawling onto the floor. I look up and see a face full of outrage, a splash of yellow and red, and... blue?

A man wearing a silly costume is staring at me. A small man, so a small costume, but one decorated with so many eye-catching colors it's almost painful to look at. I say almost, because the effect makes him ridiculous, rather than completely annoying. And his face is screwed up with a look of comical outrage.

"Buffoon! Imbecile! You think a poor performance like that is worthy of the Blighted King, ruler of all he surveys, terror of the royal banquet,

especially the poultry pies? How *dare* you, sir. Poor performances are my business!”

I try to get up, and he kicks my legs out from under me. I roll, and he throws himself on me with a cry of rage.

“What? Get off. Who are—”

There’s a chuckle, a current of mirth through the room. The man stops beating me gently with his fists and gets up, looking indignant. He bows to the Blighted King.

“Sire, I beg to show this interloper the true meaning of comedy! A hero’s one thing, but a [Clown]? I’d let a warrior take my place any day with thanks, but there can be only one fool here, and that is I, the Fool!”

He strikes an arrogant pose, managing somehow to bump me over a third time with a hip. For such a small guy, he’s got so much *force* behind him! And it doesn’t hurt when he hits me. Not at all.

The Blighted King doesn’t exactly smile, but his lips do twitch.

“Fool. You wish to perform?”

“Absolutely, Your Majesty! A [Fool] is ten times, nay, a thousand times more pitiful than a [Clown], yet twice his equal, as I shall now prove! Observe *my* juggling, if you would, dear guests of the court!”

His voice is like a stage announcer’s, only he doesn’t need a microphone. The Fool turns, all eyes on him, and flourishes. He produces a colorful ball from somewhere like I did, only this one’s higher quality and shines in the light. He tosses it up—and six more follow it.

Six. So seven are in the air at once. I hear a gasp, and then the Fool juggles them into a double weave, his hands moving so quickly I can barely

see them. He bumps me again as I try to step back to give him room, and then seems to concentrate.

“Lords and ladies, men and women, little girls who are up past their bedtime, this is what a [Fool] does! He juggles, he dances—”

The Fool spins around, catching the balls and juggling them as he twirls. He glares at me as he stops, his voice ringing.

“And he is the font of dignity, not like some sad [Clown]! How *dare* you, sir!”

He turns away, and then *farts* with a noise that can’t be real. I hear a peal of laughter from the [Princess] and surprised laughs from around the room. But I’m not in a position to laugh myself. The *smell* is real. I stumble backwards, coughing.

“Oh god. It stinks.”

And now there’s more laughter. I gag a bit as the Fool who’s also a [Fool] continues juggling, and then turns to me again, full of more fake wrath.

“You’re clearly trying to seek my job! *My* job! What will I do if my King casts me out? I should duel you right now for the dishonor of it! *Have at thee!*”

And then he starts bouncing the balls off my face as he juggles. The entire hall roars with laughter. I hold still. Contrary to what I’d hoped, the balls are made of rough leather and they hurt quite a bit, since he has to throw them hard enough to bounce back.

“Ow. Ow. Ow. Ow. Hey, that was my nose.”

It’s easy to play along with him. He’s an expert. My deadpan commentary makes the young [Princess] nearly fall over in a fit of giggles.

The Fool grins widely at me and then turns, catching the last of the balls.

“A [Fool]’s master to none and ridiculed by all, but a [Clown]!? There’s no room for two idiots in Rhir! I challenge you for the top position on the bottom, sir! *En garde!*”

He catches all the balls, bounces the last one off his left hip into my face, and then charges. Halfway towards me, he stumbles on nothing, slips, and crashes into me, sending both of us to the ground again.

“Ow.”

The Fool groans loudly, and then gets up, swinging at me and missing. He’s a master. A serious master of comedic timing, and he manages to move about me and take advantage of my presence to make everything funnier. In a few moments I’m lying on top of him, and he’s gasping for life, pulling himself away, and then charging at me with a goblet of wine that he somehow manages to get all over me before slipping in a puddle and knocking himself out on the floor.

The hall roars with laughter by the time he’s done. I’m drenched in wine, bits of food, and the shreds of my dignity. Not that I had any left to begin with.

I wipe a few stinging drops of wine out of my eyes as the [Fool] retreats, still making fists at me. At the head table, the youngest [Princess] is red-faced and nearly in tears with laughter. Even the Blighted King seems happier—although he never laughed once. He gestures towards the Fool with a nod.

“Clearly amusing. Fool, you are as always diverting in times of crisis. Thomas the [Clown]...we offer you thanks for the entertainment as well.”

His face says that I’m a freshly squeezed turd that he found on his dinner plate. The Blighted King looks away from me and at Richard and the

others. He seems to sigh.

“Very well. We shall ask for a demonstration of your Skills later, Sir Richard, and of you, Lady Emily. Be welcome in our palace until then. We hope you will not betray the hopes we place on you, brave heroes from another world.”

And like that it's over. The Blighted King motions and I trudge back to my seat with the rest of my group. Conversation resumes, mostly laughter at my expense or speculation as people eye us. The Blighted King turns to his wife and they exchange a few quiet words in their seats.

I sit down, conscious of every eye on me. Cirille gives me an odd look, and then offers me a cloth to wipe my face with. I accept it, get most of the wine off, and notice Richard and the others looking at me. I smile crookedly.

“Yeah, they're going to kick us out tomorrow. Maybe tonight.”

I'm wrong about that. I usually am, which is a relief in this case. Especially to the others. Nereshal doesn't guide us back to our rooms after the banquet himself; rather, the [Chamberlain] provides us with a few servants to show us the way.

Everyone's relieved to know we have a roof over our heads for the night. Indeed, separate rooms for all of us, no matter how small, is a luxury we've missed the entire winter. Some of the girls look so relieved to have a private space I think they could cry. We guys are obviously too stoic for that, of course.

There's a lot of chatter about what the Blighted King wants as well. Richard's room and Emily's are the largest, so over ten of us end up crammed into there. I listen as they begin talking, arguing, really.

"Do you think we can stay here forever?"

"Maybe you guys can if you get other classes, but I bet he'll make those of us with combat classes go fight soon enough."

"I'm fine with that. I just want a break."

"I think we can get at least a week or two."

Richard says that firmly, as he sits next to Emily. She's fiddling with a laptop. It's not hers. It belonged to a girl who died. I think her name was Rachel?

Reyanne. You don't remember her face, do you?

Anyways. The laptop glows with power. Emily's got it playing a song in the background. I don't recognize the lyrics—it's some kind of Spanish song, I think. Rachel—Reyanne had different tastes.

The laptop's one of our treasures. We don't have that many electronics between us all. Some were lost when we were attacked. Others were stolen, lost...and we didn't realize we could [Repair] them until later. Now everyone shares electronics, except for Emily who gets the laptop at all times.

Music, movies...I've watched the entire fifth season of Red vs Blue that Eddy had on his Android phone at least sixteen times by now. We all cling to what we have left.

But it's the iPhone that Richard carries that really matters. He stares at it, speaking out loud.

“I’d rather talk to the others again if I can, no matter how risky it is. But I haven’t gotten a call from [BlackMage] again, and I have no idea how to call him back.”

“Can we ask one of the mages here for help? They might know the people at Wistram.”

Cynthia looks desperate. Richard pauses before shaking his head.

“Too risky.”

“But—”

“We can’t necessarily trust them. What if they take away the iPhone? No, we’ve got to keep this secret, especially since the Blighted King doesn’t seem to know about the others. If we can get in contact with them, meet up or get help—”

“A way off this continent, you mean?”

Everyone looks at Vincent. Richard nods.

“I think this is our best opportunity. I was talking with Cirille—”

“She’s freakish. Unnatural.”

“Shut up, Cynthia. She’s a *Drake*, not a monster.”

“Keith—listen, she told me we can pay to send [Message] spells, or send letters. I’m not saying we should do that, because we’ll probably be spied on. But if Emily can learn to use the spell, or we can find a way to locate some of the others...”

“You think we can? What if the Blighted King...”

“He doesn’t *need* us. Richard and Emily are the only Level 30 people here.”

“Yeah, but they hit that in *three months*. It takes decades for normal people to do the same. No way he’ll let any of us go now he knows we can level like that.”

“So we’re prisoners?”

“Not if we cooperate. We’re more like allies, but we need to be cautious —”

I sigh. It’s always like this. I can’t be here. I brush at my sticky hair and decide I need a bath, and time alone. I get up and go to the door.

“You okay, Tom?”

The voices stop. Richard’s looking at me. I smile.

“Just fine.”

“That performance back there—”

“Hey, it was a one time thing. I don’t think the Blighted King cares about me. And I’m done with clowning about.”

No one laughs. Some of them still look afraid of me. I turn.

“I’m going to take a bath. Let me know if you decide anything tomorrow.”

I leave the room, hearing the buzz of conversation spring up as I shut the door. My friends.

Are they really? Or do you think they’re talking about you? Hah. You know they are. How much do they trust you, Tom? How many more times will they let you wonder before they decide to kill the scary clown before he snaps?

The voice. I stumble away towards my room. There’s nothing like a private bath there, of course, but there’s a water pitcher, and I’m not willing

to go looking around at night. My room is small, but on the level of a hotel in some respects. There's no window, no balcony, but there is a chamber pot, and a bed that's worthy of any four-star hotel. That alone makes up for the rest.

I could have done without the mirror, though. There's a large one above a dresser, another sign that this world has its form of riches. Fabrics are as high-quality as any you'd find in our world, and usually made of real materials rather than fake ones. Okay, plumbing isn't always consistent, but I know for a fact there are actual toilets elsewhere in the castle, and you can't beat the craftsmanship on the dressers.

But the mirror. It's not perfect; there are some flaws in the glass, tiny bubbles, but it reflects too much. I stare at myself. I look thin. I would have killed to lose this much weight before.

You did!

It shows too much of me. It reminds me of too much. I stare at my reflection. At my eyes.

“Are you real?”

No one answers. This mirror...slowly, I pull things out of thin air and put them on the dresser. I might as well. I pull out a greasy tin, another, smaller one, two huge shoes, and a colorful costume.

My props.

I stare at them. Oversized shoes, unfunny costume, and the face paint, white and red and black. Actually, for the black around my eyes I just use ground up charcoal. My tools of the trade.

I leave them there. I won't touch them again. Ever. I turn away, and then notice something. My costume's torn.

“Oh, right. I never got it fixed. Not since...”

Since the night. I gently unfold bits of the bright, clumsily stitched material. Cynthia made that for me, back before I scared her so much she couldn't sleep with me around. I pull at the sleeves and get a horrible surprise.

Blood. A huge splash of it across the front of the costume, and more dried and soaked into the legs. I drop the costume in horror and back away.

“No.”

I never washed it either. And now the voice in my head taunts me.

Afraid of a little blood? Why? You bathed in it when you got angry at those poor Demons. Remember how the lieutenant screamed when the horses were stampeding all over her? Remember the pain?

My breath comes quicker. I turn.

I can't stay here. Not in this room. I hurry out the door, but the voice follows me.

It's worst at night. At night, I can't escape it. In the daytime, I can distract myself, or tell myself that it's just me, just a mental disorder rearing its ugly head.

But at night, the shadows creep in, and I find sleep elusive, peace impossible. So I prowl through the castle, silent, taunted by my own thoughts.

I walk the brightly lit corridors, staring at the lights, trying not to meet the eyes of the occasional patrolling guards I run across down the empty corridors. They stare at me without much fondness.

They know who I am, at least. Hell, they probably saw me the first time when I was being escorted out with the others. Yup, here's your [Hero], guys and gals. Me. Tom the unfunny [Clown].

Only, you know you can be funny if you try.

Never. I shake my head as I enter one of the rooms Nereshal showed us earlier. It caught my eye—a room full of mirrors.

Perhaps there is some masochistic part of me, some part that loves to torture myself. But this room is where I come to. Huge, wall-to-wall mirrors cover all but the doorway, reflecting my image a thousand times. I stare around.

“Alright. Here I am. Here you are. Come on. If you're real...come out.”

I have to do this. I can't live in uncertainty forever. The voice in my head—I keep telling myself it's just me. Just me, trying to rationalize my insanity, what I went through.

But what if it's not?

These are the dark thoughts I have at night, the suspicions I can't push away without daylight. My fears.

I went insane. I went crazy and killed people. That much the others believe. That I know happened. And I'm sure it was me. Mostly sure. But, the thought whispers, what if it *wasn't* me?

What if the [Lesser Insanity] condition isn't some part of me, but something else? The madness—I can remember laughing as I stabbed the Demon lieutenant. I can remember the pain. Gods, the *pain*. But I also remember how I felt.

It wasn't me.

But it was.

But it wasn't. In the darkness, I feel certain. In that moment, when I held Wilen, I didn't care. I reached out, and let something in. Something dark. Did I open the door somehow?

Did you? Or is it just you? Are you holding me back? Or am I just an excuse, Tom?

"Go away."

I stare at the mirror ahead of me. There's a feeling in my head, a bit of madness. I can feel it worming its way around. I know the mirror is just a reflection of me. It shows my clothing, stained, and my face, tired, my eyes a bit bloodshot. Me in perfect detail. I know that's all it is.

But something tells me that's not all. Something tells me there's something *else* staring back behind the glass. What?

"Who are you?"

Who are you?

"I know you're there. I can feel you. Hear you. My shadows move when I don't look. My eyes—"

Normal eyes. But if I look away, do they keep staring? I try it. Turning my head and looking back quickly. But the mirror me reflects perfectly each time. I grit my teeth.

"Move, damn you. If you're going to play tricks on me—"

I reach out and touch the glass. I stare into my reflection's eyes, daring it to move, to twitch even a second. Tom stares back, pallid, sleep-deprived, wide-eyed. He grins at me.

I stop smiling. So does my reflection. Damn it, it's all in my head.

All? Are you sure?

It has to be. I take my hand away, noting with guilt that I've smudged the mirror. I try to polish it, but just spread the oils from my palm around.

"I hate you. If you're there, I'll kill you. I swear it."

You? You and what madness?

Laughter. The voice isn't the worst. The voice sounds like me at times, a bit crazy, darker, but still what I'd think. The voice only scares me at times. But it's when *I* feel like laughing, like punching the glass until my hand is full of shards, that I'm afraid.

It would be so easy. So easy to push the glass deep. What would it feel like if it hit bone? I make a fist, staring at my stupid expression. My eyes.

"Well, I expected to be alone, but I suppose I was a fool for thinking that. More proof that I'm good at my job, then."

A voice. I whirl, and see a short man in colorful clothing. The Fool. He walks into the room with a brisk step. He's got a bottle in hand and a cup. He nods at me, not smiling, but not frowning, either.

"Mister [Clown]. I didn't think to see you tonight."

"Ah. You're..."

He puts the bottle and cup on the ground and gives me a dramatic bow.

"A [Fool], at your service, sir. And you may call me Fool—everyone else does. I perform at the Blighted King's court. I hope you didn't take too much offense at my little performance?"

"What? No. I—it bailed me out. Thanks."

"We funny men should stick together. Only, you're fairly *unfunny* as such people go. Are you truly a [Clown], Mister...?"

"Oh. Sorry. I'm Tom. Thomas, but you can call me Tom."

The Fool takes my hand and shakes it with a surprisingly firm grip. He's not nearly as dramatic as he was in the banquet hall earlier, but there's still a sense of performing as he indicates the mirror behind me.

"Come to admire yourself in the room of mirrors? It's a rare person who likes to spend time here. I confess, that's why I came alone."

"Sorry about that. I can leave if you want—"

"Nonsense. There's more than enough space for two idiots, or at least one [Fool] and a [Clown]. Besides, company is pleasant, and if you've a mind to share it, I wouldn't take it amiss. I'm never alone here as you can tell."

He nods to his reflections. I smile a bit.

"Sure. What are you doing here?"

"Drinking. Of course! A bottle of wine, a cup...would you like one?"

"A cup? Sure, but if there's only one—"

He hands me a second cup, already filled with wine. I stare at it and blink at him. The Fool grins.

"Well?"

Gingerly I sip at the cup. Then I frown. I tilt the cup towards my lips, but no liquid comes out. I can see it, red and deep in the cup! I tilt it further, and then on a hunch, upend the cup. Nothing comes out. I stare at the Fool and he grins.

"A little trick. I apologize, but the joke's only good once, so I do it to everyone I meet. That's a fake cup, you see?"

"I do. But how do you get the liquid...?"

"Oh, I copied this cup, of course."

The Fool hands me a second cup, identical to the first, only the wine sloshes about in this one. He takes the first cup back and tosses it to the ground. It breaks into pieces which dissolve into nothing.

“It’s a Skill of mine, to copy things. They last a while too, if handled gently. Good for pranks and trickery. Not for much else. But then, you’d know about such Skills, wouldn’t you?”

“I suppose I would. I am a [Clown], by the way. Just a bad one. I’m only Level 28.”

The Fool’s eyebrows rise.

“And yet you had no levels when you first came here. I’d say that’s astonishing by any standards. A shame you can’t perform as well. Your juggling act was painful to watch.”

“Sorry.”

He claps me on the back. I slosh some of the wine.

“Nonsense! Again, nonsense, so I suppose it must be tomfoolery! Stop apologizing and don’t mind the spill. Servants will catch it. If not, bugs. What you need is practice. A week or so and you’ll have the court rolling at your feet. Who knows, you might get His Dour Majesty to smile!”

“You mean the Blighted King? I’ll pass. I’m done with being a [Clown].”

“Ah. Not much of a warrior you said?”

“Not much. Sorry. I—I guess you know all about us.”

The Fool shrugs. He takes a sip from the wine bottle, letting it slosh into his mouth from high above. *He* doesn’t spill a drop, which is impressive.

“The whole court knows, I daresay, and much of the kingdom. We had such hopes. Alas, prophecy is not what it’s rumored to be.”

“About that. Are we really the destined heroes that are supposed to save Rhir from the blight and the Demon King? No one’s really mentioned that.”

“Well, that’s what the spell says. Summons heroes destined to glory and all that. I don’t know much about it, but the Blighted King and his advisors seemed to think that meant you were fairly competent.”

“Hah.”

“That’s what I thought! But I was wise enough not to make a joke about it. How His Majesty raged when he heard of what happened to you.”

Somehow, I find myself sitting with the Fool, drinking from my cup as he fills it and drinks himself. He tells me about the Blighted King and his role at court.

“One must have a [Fool]. Actually, I lie. One mustn’t at all, even if one is a [King]. My class is rare enough, and there’s scant work for a [Fool] in hungry villages. I was lucky enough to catch His Majesty’s eye one day, and I have served here for over a decade.”

“A decade? Really? Wow. I thought [Fools] were supposed to be part of a court. Like it was a hereditary thing, or something.”

“Hah! Fools breeding more fools! What a world that would be! I’m afraid that Rhir, at least, doesn’t see the need for a line of my ilk. Although if I met a lovely lady...alas, they go for heroes of the realm, not idiots juggling balls.”

“You’d think the more balls the merrier, right?”

He chokes on his wine, coughs, and laughs.

“So Tom the [Clown] has a joke in him after all! A bit crass, though. I wouldn’t dare repeat it at court.”

“Oh come on. It’s funny.”

The Fool grows serious.

“Yes, but it wouldn’t be appropriate for the young [Princess]. You noted her at the table, I hope. Her and the other [Princess], of course. They are our King’s daughters.”

“I saw. She looks young.”

“She’s the daughter of the current Blighted Queen. Alas, her sister, whom we call Her Highness Isodore, is the daughter of the previous Blighted Queen.”

“So there’s been more than one?”

“You hadn’t heard? Of course not. Yes, there have been two Blighted Queens. Three, if you count the one who died before marriage. The Blighted King has seen his wives die one by one during his reign.”

“That...sucks.”

“An understatement, which is why I am so sorely needed at his court. Not that the Blighted King laughs, mind you. But I keep the [Princess] and others amused, so I earn my keep. I also endeavor to stay away from lewd jokes or more intimate comedy unless I know she’s asleep.”

“That’s nice of you.”

The Fool shakes his head. He smiles sadly.

“The [Princess] has a hard life without me adding to it, Mister Tom.”

“Just Tom, please.”

“Very well. I’m surprised, to be honest, that you took a class so odd as a [Clown]. What do you do, exactly, if it’s not make people laugh?”

“Make them feel uncomfortable, I suppose. And laugh at how weird I am.”

“Like a [Fool]! But surely there’s more of a difference. What makes a [Clown] different from a [Fool]?”

“I dunno. Face paint? I wear oversized shoes, have a big red nose, use balloons...”

“What?”

“Uh—it’s a round floaty thing.”

He stares at me. I shrug. I’m pleasantly sloshed by now and feeling... decent for once. I try describing it to him and he shakes his head.

“Loud, noisy, and can fly? I’d use one myself if I had such a thing. I make do with throwing squirrels and cats in the meantime. But surely there’s more to it than that.”

I sigh.

“I don’t know. Clowns come in all different shapes and sizes. I guess [Fools] are like that too. For instance, I don’t see you wearing a jingling cap with bells.”

“That’s a requirement for being a [Fool]?”

“I mean, that’s what I think of. Why don’t you have one of those?”

He gives me a look.

“I’m a [Fool], not an idiot. There are times when a Fool should be seen and not heard, or not seen or heard at all. Were I to go around dinging like some bell, I’d be evicted from the royal presence within the hour.”

He paused.

“Perhaps the day if the youngest [Princess] were to object.”

“She really likes you, huh?”

“I’m her sole form of entertainment on some days, and it can be dreary being locked up in the palace. She never enters the city without an escort and seldom at that.”

“Why? Is it so dangerous here? I thought the capital—”

He waves a hand and refills my goblet.

“Oh, it’s safer than any other part of Rhir and safe for all but royalty I imagine. Yet the [Princess] must be careful, or she’ll end up like her brothers and sisters.”

“I thought she only had a sister. Or—”

“She *had* others.”

Like an idiot, I stare at the Fool blankly.

“What happened to them, then? Where are they?”

His voice is flat.

“Dead.”

I sober up a bit.

“Oh. I’m s—I thought it was a family of four—”

“The majesties royal had a household of *seven*, once, unfunny Tom. Two older sons and another daughter three years older than the young [Princess]. All of them died. The brothers in battle, and the daughter in bed. A plague, sent by the Demons it was thought. Assassins killed the last Queen, and the one before that.”

“Oh.”

The Fool nods. He isn't smiling now. He stares at his reflection in one of the mirrors.

“Now the [Princess] and Her Young Highness Isodore are watched like sheep by lions, while their father and mother strive to make their kingdom safe for all but their enemies. A touching tale, isn't it?”

I nod and sip from his wine flask. Did one of the mirror images of me just wink? Nope. Just my imagination. Again.

“For a [Fool], you're awfully well-informed. And you seem important.”

“Shouldn't I be? I am a royal jester, a prince of laughter. Shouldn't I be known and heard, but never minded in court? I can walk around and people talk as if I don't exist. Which I don't mind, incidentally.”

The Fool gets up and does a cartwheel, laughing, half in mirth, half in a kind of despair I recognize. He turns to me.

“You're no [Clown] you say, but if you're not that, what are you? In denial, I should imagine.”

“No, no—you wouldn't like to see me when I'm a [Clown]. Really.”

“How should I see you, then?”

“Just as Tom. Tom the unfunny, who could use a refill of your wine, if you've got any left, Fool. I don't suppose you can copy the wine bottle? Or do you have access to more wine we could find?”

He stares at me, a smile tugging at his lips.

“I don't believe I've ever met a person who wanted to befriend me, Tom. Are you that bored, or am I that good company?”

“Neither. But us unfunny people should stick together, right?”

I grin at him and feel happy for a tiny bit. The Fool blinks at me, and then laughs. Of all the people I've met today, his laughter is the only one I've needed. And it heals something. That night I pass out in my room, drunk, but sane.

And a bit happy.

The next day, I'm too hung over to have breakfast, and barely have lunch with the others. I keep rubbing my head and groaning, and when they decide to go out to explore the city, I beg off.

"God, Tom. How much did you drink last night?"

"And where can I get some?"

Emily glares at me while Eddy edges over. I shake my head.

"Ask the Fool."

"Him? Where'd you meet him?"

"We raided the kitchens. There's a lot. Good...ow, my head hurts."

"I think Tom's going to rest. Alright, let's go the rest of you. We have a budget, remember, but we'll make sure everyone has some coin. Tom, can you give us the money if you're staying behind?"

"Sure. Here."

I toss the pouch at Richard and stumble away to my room. After two more hours, I feel able to function normally, so I finally get up and stumble out of the palace.

I get lost six times along the way. The corridors are a complete maze to me, and they're apparently meant to be that way. No invading army can enter that easily. Unfortunately, that means I have to bother person after person to find my way out.

I get all the way to the courtyard when I realize I have no money, no real desire to see the sights, and no idea why I'm here. I stare glumly around the huge open area leading up to the castle.

"Man, this place is big."

You could march an army through here. Heck, that's probably the point. There are three gates leading into the courtyard, which head up to the double doors after a flight of steps. The wall around the courtyard is high, but the space itself is so big that it doesn't feel enclosed at all.

It's quite nice, actually. There's a fountain and lots of water over there, some greenery over there, very nice stonework underfoot...and that's all I've got.

You really need a hobby. Like stabbing people.

"Shush. I was in a good mood before you showed up."

You should turn around. Someone's standing behind you.

"I said shush."

"Can you really not do anything but juggle? Father says you have hidden depths."

That voice is real. I nearly jump out of my skin as I whirl around. A young girl wearing a violet dress takes a step back. She stares up at me. I blink down at the youngest [Princess] of the Blighted Kingdom.

"Uh. What?"

She stares at me. I stare back. She points at my chest.

“Can you do a backflip? The Fool can.”

“What? I—probably not, Your Highness.”

I probably can, actually. If it’s part of my [Flawless Dodge] routine or... heck, I learned how to do an okay cartwheel. But I’m not certain why the [Princess] is here, and I’m busy looking around for the guards that *should* be around her.

There’s no one in the courtyard. The [Princess] stares at me and speaks matter-of-factly.

“If you don’t know how, the Fool can teach you. He wouldn’t teach me, but he could teach you and I could watch.”

“Okay? If I see him, I’ll ask.”

“He’s over there. You can ask now.”

She points. I turn around. Now how did I miss the Fool? Oh, right. He’s not wearing his eye-catching costume.

A little man wearing nondescript clothing is standing about sixty feet away, walking about the courtyard absentmindedly. He has something in his hands. It looks like...a scroll.

He’s speaking to the air with the scroll unfurled. The [Princess] and I stare at him. Then she looks at me.

“Are you going to ask or not?”

She’s *pushy*. I step over to the Fool, more because I have nothing else to do than any desire to do backflips. He spots us as we approach and rolls up his scroll. He stares at me and then the [Princess] with a furrowed brow.

“I knew we had fun last night, but this much? And what are you doing in the company of the Princess, Mister Tom?”

“She appeared out of nowhere. She wants me to ask you to teach her how to do backflips?”

“*What?*”

The Fool’s eyes widen and he does a standing backflip, pretending to be aghast. The [Princess] claps her hands together, laughing. The Fool obliges her, and then peers at me.

“I’m surprised she spoke to you. Our little Princess speaks to few people.”

“He’s funny. So are you.”

The Princess informs the Fool in the same decisive voice. He raises his eyebrows at her, and then turns to me.

“Well, that’s interesting. I suppose you’d better entertain her yourself, Mister Tom. Go on, do a backflip.”

“What? No! I’ve never done one before.”

“It’s not hard. Go on. If you break your neck, it’ll be twice as amusing, I promise.”

I back up and raise my hands as the two pester me. In desperation, I point to the scroll the Fool tucked into his belt.

“What was that about? Were you talking to someone?”

“That’s a magic scroll. For talking to people.”

The [Princess] peeks at the Fool’s belt. He dances back, and wags a finger at her.

“Ah, ah! That’s mine, [Princess]. And as for who I was talking to... would you believe the love of my heart?”

He looks at us hopefully. I stare at him. The Fool scowls and bounces one of his juggling balls off my head. The [Princess] giggles. Then the Fool looks at her. There's something parental about the way he does it.

"As delighted as I am to see you, you and I both know you shouldn't be out here alone, young Miss. Why have you wandered off?"

The young girl immediately loses her smile. She scuffs at the ground with a shoe.

"Father sent the soldiers away. All of them. I don't like that."

The Fool stiffens. I look at him, confused.

"What?"

He looks gravely at me.

"That was a secret, my inquisitive friend. A state secret, so pretend you didn't hear it if you know what's best. Your Highness, you know you shouldn't speak of such things. I understand you're worried, but all will be well."

She doesn't look convinced. I don't know what the hell's going on, so I draw the Fool away. He tosses her one of his juggling balls to keep her company as he whispers in my ear.

"What the young Princess is referring to is a strategic decision the [King] came up with two days ago. With the exception of a few foreign regiments and the King's own guard, every soldier has been deployed to the Fourth Wall. In preparation for an upcoming battle."

"Sounds serious."

He grimaces.

“No more than any battle is in Rhir. But it is a tactical decision. And one that cannot be shared, you understand? No one knows about this, save for the King and his advisors. And me, of course.”

“You?”

“Because of her.”

He nods at the Princess.

“Oh.”

The Fool’s eyes are sad as he looks at the young girl. She’s dropped the ball and bends down to get it. Then she catches herself and does some kind of curtsy instead. She snatches the ball back up, and begins tossing it up again.

“If she says something, Mister Tom, it’s because she’s worried. The [Princess] understands war, I’m afraid. And His Majesty, the wise and tragic King of the Blighted Kingdom...does not understand how much his children hear, I am afraid.”

“Oh.”

“Quite. Now, do help me get her back to the castle.”

He leads me back, pretending to scold me out loud.

“I keep telling you, broken bones are a sign of comedy, young Tom. We’ll make a proper [Fool] of you yet. If not that, I’m sure you’ll be a fine [Idiot]. And you should not be wandering around unattended, Your Royal Highness.”

He pretends to be stern. The [Princess] frowns and stamps a foot.

“I don’t like my guards. I left them.”

“And it is a fine joke to leave an escort of trained warriors behind by yourself. But I see someone’s not amused by your tricks.”

He turns and points. I turn. How do I not see people coming up from behind? Now I see another young woman, the same one who was sitting by the Blighted King yesterday.

“Your Highness.”

The Fool bows to Princess Isodore. I do too, clumsily. She stares at me and the Fool, giving me a frown, the Fool an exasperated look, and the young Princess a stern one.

“Where have you been? Your guards are searching for you in a panic. Nereshal was about to scry around for you!”

“He can’t scry me if I’m wearing this!”

The young Princess raises a ring triumphantly. She’s wearing two. Isodore glares at her half-sister.

“He can comb the area, and he will if you don’t come back. And if he does, he’ll be angry and Father will know about it.”

“I don’t want to go back! I want to learn to backflip!”

The [Princess] hides behind the Fool and me like any kid her age. Only she’s royalty and Isodore’s not alone. A group of men and women in armor rush out of the open palace doors after Isodore. I gulp, and Isodore glares at her sister.

“Come on. You have to go back.”

“I will go with Her Highness, if she wishes.”

The Fool interjects, and the [Princess] brightens. But Isodore holds up a hand.

“I’m sorry, Fool, but my sister can’t be hand-held the entire time. Nor will your presence calm Nereshal. I think it would make things worse, to be honest. Come, Erille. Do you want to get the Fool in trouble?”

“No.”

Reluctantly, Princess Erille comes out from behind the Fool. She stares longingly at me and him, and Isodore gives us another look. She stares at me for a second with a look I recognize.

“You will excuse me, Sir Thomas. And you, Fool. Come, Erille.”

The two Princesses turn and meet up with their escort, who surround them in a second. I watch them walk slowly back to the palace and turn to the Fool. He’s still staring at Erille’s back. Sadly. At last he shakes himself and looks at me.

“Isodore doesn’t seem to like you, Sir Thomas.”

He says the name mockingly. I sigh.

“She saw us when we were first here, I bet. She probably thinks I’m a fraud.”

The Fool nods.

“Oh, the whole kingdom did. I daresay that my role was made useless for a fortnight after you arrived. So many jokes were told—one merely had to wave around a Goblin’s head for the courtiers to roll around laughing!”

Then he pauses.

“But I suppose there might be more to it than disappointment.”

“How do you mean?”

He looks at me, cocking his head to one side, standing on one leg, seemingly back to his good spirits or pretending to be at least.

“You were abed and I was out and about, performing at breakfast, so you must have missed today’s gossip. It was about you. You claim to be naught but a former [Clown], but there have been rumors this morning about you, Tom.”

“Oh no. Really?”

I can’t imagine who started the rumors. But maybe Emily, or Cynthia, or Eddy, that bastard? It’s possible...the Fool nods.

“The court and His Majesty have heard you’re more than you seemed, Mister Unfunny Tom. I hear you can be quite amusing. And deadly. Her Highness may have heard the same.”

He turns back to look at Isodore and Erille. They’re still walking across the courtyard. Man, is it big. And they can’t exactly move fast in their ballroom-style dresses.

“Don’t mind her. She fears so many; one more is hardly her fault. As for Erille...”

He trails as he stares at the young Princess. She’s happily occupied as she tosses the ball the Fool gave her up and tries to catch it before it lands. She never gave it back, and I don’t think the Fool would ever ask.

It’s not hard to imagine what’s there. A Fool who’s more friend and father than her actual father, and a kid trapped in a castle. And the other Princess—Isodore looks back and then turns instantly when she sees me staring at her.

I look away.

“I’m no one, Fool. No one special.”

“So you say, Tom.”

He leaves me there, and I wander back towards the palace, feeling disconsolate. But I realize something as I walk through the corridors. Something interesting. And maybe hopeful.

Whenever I'm with the Fool, I can't hear the voice in my head. I don't know why that is. Maybe he's just that entertaining, or just that nice a guy that I don't want to kill him. Or maybe it's something else?

That night we have another banquet. And for once, I'm feeling good enough to eat a lot. We sit with the Drakes again, but there's more of a sense of inclusion this time. We are, at least in some respects now, guests, and aside from a lot of bad jokes aimed at me, everything's great.

Which isn't to say there aren't more tests. This time, it's Richard and Emily's turn, but they at least seem up to the task. Emily performs several spells in front of the court, raising a wave of water out of the ground, creating a perfect sphere that she rolls across the floor. I can tell Princess Erille would love to chase after it, but she's stuck at the high table.

Then it's Richard's turn. Today, I get more of a sense of who sits in the Blighted King's castle. Among the more important guests who sit closer to the head of the hall are groups of what I can only call the Blighted King's champions. Rugged men, women, and representatives of other species, most wearing shining armor, magical equipment, and holding an air of power around them.

There's a Minotaur with black fur, a half-Elf man with a staff that stands on its own when he's not holding it, a pale Selphid with two greatswords resting by his table, and a whole bevy of [Knights] and warriors who look like they'd fit in any grand story of knights and honor.

They're all high-level, and as the feast begins, several of them get up to engage in duels. They use real armor, but wooden weapons, and they strike, parry, block, and dodge like the coolest movie action scene I've ever seen.

Cooler, because they move faster than an actor does with choreographed moves. I see one warrior wearing chainmail leap *over* a woman with a wooden spear and slash at her head. Too bad that the instant his feet touch the ground, the spear warrior vaults over to him with the spear as a pole and kicks his lights out.

Richard is called to spar the spear wielder after that. I hear my friends cheering as he gets up, wiping his hands and taking the practice sword offered to him. The spear wielder touches her blunt spear tip against the wooden sword and then begins dashing at Richard, spear jabbing at him in a blur. She whirls her spear and it lashes Richard from all sides, a hail of lightning-fast blows.

"Holy crap."

I can't believe Richard can defend against any of that, but he actually manages to parry several strikes and attack back. He ends up defeated, but he does so well, apparently, that there's a round of applause for him afterwards.

I see Richard stagger back as the spear wielder offers him a hand up. The old woman claps him on the shoulders and leads him towards the table with the other champions to cheers from my table. I watch Richard talking with the others with a familiar camaraderie.

Jealous?

"No. Richard deserves that. He fought hard and earned it."

I hear a mocking laugh in my head, but someone replies out loud as well.

“Sir Richard is a skilled warrior, worthy of his [Knight] class. Since he has reached Level 30, he is considered a peer of the realm in many respects. All those with a level higher than 30 are honored in various ways by the crown.”

I find a man standing at my side, holding a goblet of wine and looking politely at me. He looks...familiar. He has dark skin, a scar over his temple, and the look of someone who knows how to use a weapon. He nods at me.

“Sir Thomas. I am pleased to meet you. I missed the chance this morning.”

“Um. Hi.”

He speaks as if we should know each other. He looks towards the next duel, between a [Mage] and a man with a bow who keeps shooting at the shimmering field around the mage as he dodges.

“Such displays are common. Rhir has a number of tournaments hosted year round, and offers coin to anyone willing to teach or display their skills from around the world. Martial prowess is prized here above all else.”

“When you’re at war, I guess that’s how it has to be, huh?”

I look toward the Blighted King.

“Can he fight? The King?”

The man shakes his head.

“His Majesty is not known for his abilities on the field of battle, which is not to say he does not appear there if the need is dire. On the other hand, Her Majesty is at least as skilled a warrior as they are. She was known for her prowess with a mace before she married the King.”

“I can believe that.”

She looks like someone who knows how to fight. On cue, I hear a voice.

I wonder if she could block you if you stabbed her up close. What if you held her daughter hostage?

I shake my head slightly. The man notices.

“She is quite a fine warrior, as is your friend. He deserves his spot among the King’s champions. However, I deem your skills as equal to theirs in at least some respects, Sir Thomas.”

I stare at him.

“I’m sorry, but have we met? I don’t recall.”

He smiles slightly.

“I would not begrudge you that. I had the honor of meeting you in the village of Rastfad, shortly after your defeat of—”

Of the Demons. He was one of the people who saw me after I slaughtered them. I remember. I stare at the man.

“Are you—were you—”

He bows slightly.

“Captain Kirust, at your service. I returned to the capital last night, but was too late to participate in the feast. I attended this morning and was delighted to find your company well, sir.”

“Hang on, *you’re* the one who’s been spreading rumors about me? Stop it. Please. I’m not a warrior.”

“I would beg to disagree, sir. I saw what you did to defend the villagers, and I cannot believe such a man would be lesser to any [Knight] of the realm.”

“I—no. That was one thing. I went crazy back then. You saw me laughing, covered in blood.”

He stares at me. I feel the ground breaking away under my feet. Unsteady. Someone’s laughing in my head.

They love you for what you are, Tom. Embrace it. They love you. You, the slaughterer. They cheered you after you laughed among the dead.

“Sir Thomas, I spoke to His Majesty today and spoke highly of your abilities. I do not mean to force you to fight, but you should at least be awarded the accolades of your true merits.”

“I don’t want that. I don’t want that at all.”

He looks confused.

“But Sir Thomas—”

“Stop calling me that. Just call me—Tom. I’m no warrior, get it? I don’t ever want to do that again.”

“Not even if there are more innocents at risk?”

His eyes are steady on mine. I hear a buzzing in my ears.

“I arrived too late to save the people. From what I understand, your comrades fled. But you stayed and fought, and defeated over *thirty* trained Demon warriors and a *Troll*—”

“I didn’t want to! I’m not proud of it! Don’t celebrate me for being a murderer!”

My voice is raised. I turn to leave, but Kirust’s eyes are on me. His voice is in my ears, and the laughter.

“Sir Thomas, the kingdom has warriors, but it has few heroes. A man such as yourself—”

A hero. I turn and grab Kirust and lift him up. I've always been strong. The [Captain] stares at me, alarmed, fear in his eyes as I draw him close with a snarl. That's right. That's the fear. That's honest.

"I'm not a warrior! I told you that! I didn't *want* to kill them! I'd rather die than do it again! I won't lose control, I won't give in! Not now, not ever, no matter what the cost! *I'm not a hero, do you understand?*"

I realize I'm shouting too late. I let go of Kirust and look around. Everyone's staring at me. I stumble away from the [Captain] and hurry out of the feast hall.

Madness.

I stay in my room for hours after that, staring into the mirror. I throw the bloody clown suit to the floor, and begin pulling everything out of the trick space. My juggling balls, juggling pins, a dead flower, a few coins, and—knives.

I stare at them. I picked up one or two after that night. For self-defense. I *had* a bunch of swords, but I couldn't keep them there. Swords, knives, arrows—I can remember pulling them out of the hands of the other soldiers, stabbing people with them, *laughing*.

Good times.

One of the knives is sharp, the other one sharper, but that's a kitchen knife. It's not meant for combat, although it can certainly be used as such. I pick up one of the knives and feel it. Perfectly weighted, great for throwing. Another one's unbalanced, because it's not meant for that.

But if I throw it—I toss the knife gingerly towards a wall. It rotates through the air and strikes the wall. Hilt-first.

“Of course, [Unerring Throw] doesn’t mean everything.”

I pick the knife up, and flip it in my hands. I catch it by the hilt easily. I’m not worried about cutting myself. The first Skill, the only Skill I got from my [Hero] class was [Weapon Proficiency: Knives].

“So why can’t I throw them correctly? Not enough rotation? Enough force?”

I guess proficiency with knives doesn’t mean I can throw them like a master. Still, I can do a lot of tricks with them. [Sleight of Hand] combined with my proficiency means I can practically walk my knife across my hand.

And flip it into the air and catch it without getting cut. I do it with my eyes closed, and then play the knife game. I tap the tip between my fingers on the dresser rapidly, then spin it up again. Catch it.

It would be so easy to just let it fall and cut my hand off. Or stand in front of the blade. I grab the knife out of the air when I think that and stare at it. Then the door opens.

“Tom? We wanted to see if you were okay—”

A voice. I turn. Chole pushes open the door to my room. She stops when she sees me, holding the knife, staring at her. I realize what it looks like too late. I take a step towards her and make the mistake of gesturing with the blade.

“Uh, look. I know—”

She screams and runs. I curse and put the knife up my sleeve, making it vanish. *Why* do I have such bad timing?

In seconds, other people appear around the door. I hold up a hand.

“Nothing crazy. Just practicing knife throwing, guys.”

“Right. Right.”

They nod and grin at me. Sick, pale excuses for grins. I look at them. They shut the door. I stand in the darkness.

I’m going crazy. I am. I walk down the corridors of the palace, feeling it in my veins. It’s getting worse. I can’t control it anymore.

And worse, at the moment I can’t hear the voice. Normally that would be a good sign. Now I’m afraid.

Why was I playing with a knife? Why did I *want* to stand under the blade? Why did I shout at Kirust? Why, why, why—

I’m losing it. I turn down another brightly lit corridor, scowling at the mage lights. I hate the brightness. But maybe it’s a good thing it’s bright. At least I can’t imagine things in the—

Shadows.

I stop. I don’t know where I am, but I suddenly see something at odds with the brightly lit passageways behind me. Ahead, there are no mage lights. Only blackness. Thick and consuming.

“What? What’s...?”

I look over my shoulder. A shining light hangs in the hallway behind me. Ahead of me...darkness. No light.

I feel a chill. What’s this? This is like a bad—bad horror movie. Or something else. I look at the light behind me again. And then ahead.

“Hello?”

The darkness...calls to me. I take a step forwards. Where are the mage lights? They have to be here. They said—

This is it. I’ve gone insane. Or this is real. I reach out and my hand is suddenly grasping a knife.

Darkness. It can’t be a coincidence. In a castle where the light is supposed to be on all the time? I feel a presence. And I know.

“This is it, isn’t it? You’re here. You’re messing with me. It isn’t just me. Is it?”

No response. I take a step forwards, hesitate. Every instinct tells me I should back away from the darkness. But why? I have nothing to lose. And if I turn away, I’ll always wonder if I was going crazy or not.

If I die, at least I’ll know. I hold my knife at the ready.

“I won’t run. Not this time. I’m coming for you, do you hear me?”

My voice is loud, but still sucked up by some kind of unnatural silence. I walk forwards. Now I can barely see anything. But I can hear... something.

Whispering. Footfalls. I turn my head. Nothing’s there. The voice in my head is gone.

I feel something is nearby.

“I know you’re there. Come on.”

A movement. I spin. Just the darkness. I really am losing it.

It’s in my head. It’s right here. I’m going insane. This is reality. The darkness closes in, and then I think I see a light. I feel my way down a corridor. Yes, there’s something ahead of me.

Is this it? Suddenly, I see a bright light and realize I'm an idiot. One of the mage lights just went out! And I thought...I thought...

I'm losing it. But then I walk forwards a bit more and realize it's not a mage light ahead. Instead, I see an advancing ghostly blue flame. A... lantern's light. Yes, ahead of me. Moving.

Dark. A flicker of movement. My heart races. There *is* something here. Something—

Him. Me.

Then I step closer, and see what's holding the light. The figure turns, and the lantern swings. I see a face like leather, two horns curving downwards, bright green eyes—

A Demon soldier stands with lantern in hand, a bloody sword in the other. I stop, staring. He stares back. And behind him, I see a man with his back against the wall, next to an ornate door. He sees me at the same time I see him.

"Fool?"

He half turns towards me and I see his eyes widening. He shouts.

"Get away, Tom! Warn the others! There are Demons—"

The Demon soldier whirls around. He raises his sword with a snarl and the Fool raises his hands. The Demon strikes low.

He slashes the Fool's belly open, pulling out a chunk of his insides. The Fool gasps, grips onto the Demon as if to hold him there. The masked Demon lowers him, almost gently, to the floor, and turns towards me. His horns flash in the light of the lantern he's holding.

I back away. This is a nightmare. Only, it's not one I thought would be here. My hand rises, it shakes as I hold the knife in front of me. And now I

hear the voice.

Kill him. You know you want to.

“Stay back!”

The Demon advances on me. Then he stops. A hand grasps his cloven feet. The Fool. He whispers something up at the Demon. The soldier turns and kicks the Fool in the face. I hear a *crack* and the Fool goes still.

The Demon turns back towards me, sword in hand. I back up again. The voice is whispering, shouting.

Kill him! Slash him, leap at him and take his sword! You're too afraid to do it? Let me out! Give in! LET ME OUT AND I'LL DEAL WITH ALL OF IT.

No, no! I shake my head, trembling. I can't—I won't! But the Demon is approaching, sword bloody. It drips to the ground. I back up again.

I have to run. I have to fight. I have to—

GIVE IN.

Madness. I want to laugh. I want to cry. I want to scream—the Demon looks at me, and whirls. He runs towards the door the Fool was standing in front of and picks something up. A key. Only now do I see another body, next to the Fool's. A man in armor, gutted. There's blood on the ground. And the key—

The Demon turns it in the lock. He throws the door open and rushes inside. I freeze. Then I hear a high-pitched scream. It's a voice I recognize.

Erille's. I don't recall running to the door, but now I stand inside it. The Demon is inside, and so is Erille. The room is huge, beautiful. She's sitting in a four-poster bed, eyes wide. The Demon towers over her, one clawed hand reaching for her, grabbing.

Her eyes are wide. The Demon's pulling at her, the bloody sword in his hands. He'll kill her.

LET ME OUT.

"No!"

I scream the word, and throw. The Demon twists, eyes staring at me, and freezes. Erille shrieks in horror and I hear a sound I'll remember forever.

Thunk.

The blade stops, embedded in the Demon's forehead. He blinks, reaches up to feel at the piece of metal in his head. He never completes the motion, but slumps onto the bed, half over Erille. She screams again.

"Are you alright?"

I run over to her. She screams at me. I pull the Demon off her, and the girl is screaming, pulling the covers over her face. I reach for her, hesitate. There's someone laughing in my head. But I did that! I—

"Behind!"

Her voice makes me whirl. I turn, and there's a second shape in the doorway. Another Demon, with two knives in his hands. He stares at the fallen Demon on the ground and roars at me.

GIVE—

This time I push the voice down. I stare at the Demon and he stares back. Now my blood is on fire. And I know what I have to do.

I charge the second Demon. He might be tall, but I'm *heavy*. We crash into each other and I feel him stabbing, quick as lightning. His knife goes into my stomach, one, two, three, *four*—

The blade vanishes. I yank it away from him and now it's in my hands. He stabs towards my face before jerking away, realizing his hand is now empty. I slash at him, but we're too locked together.

We roll on the floor as the [Princess] flees her bed. All I can see is the Demon's face. His eyes are wide, green—he has no whites, just green sclera and yellow pupils shaped like diamonds, locked on me.

I can hear laughter, I can feel the madness taking over. But I fight it down as I stab back at the Demon. I'm in control! In this eternal moment of death and violence I realize it. It's just me. I scream it at him.

“It's me! I'm in control! *Me! This is my choice!*”

I'll kill. I stab the knife and feel it enter something. The Demon stabs me with his other knife, twisting the blade. I've felt pain before. I push mine deeper, deeper.

He stops moving. The lance of metal tears into me again. It's just his hands and mine, seeking each other's lives. I look at the Demon, straight into his eyes, and he looks at me.

“You and I—are both monsters.”

His eyes widen. His grip on the dagger loosens. I feel his claws tearing at my belly, and then relax. He stiffens, and I push myself off him.

The dagger—his dagger—is shoved hilt-deep into his chest, right where his heart would be if he's like a Human. He's covered in blood.

My blood.

I stagger upright, feeling a gaping...emptiness in my chest. I hear a sound. I turn, and Erille flinches away from me. I look down and see only blood and torn flesh where my chest should be.

“Oh. Sorry.”

I'm scaring her. I look at the Demon at the foot of her bed, and then the one at my feet.

Two Demons. Both dead. I did that. I did.

I should be angry, or sad. Or shocked. But I just stare at them. Dead. That's all.

I killed them. I did it. But that doesn't matter. I don't care. What's important is—is—

Blood drips to the floor. I turn to Erille. She huddles in her blankets, eyes wide, staring. But it's important she knows. There's no danger anymore. None.

"Just me. I did it. I'm—"

I stare down at my bloody hands and feel the deep cuts on my belly bleeding. The pain—I've felt worse. I clench my fingers tightly around the dagger still buried in my side. It hurts. But I'm me.

There's no one else in here. Just Tom. Tom the [Clown].

Tom the Murderer.

"You should probably scream for help. Or something."

I tell Erille that as I slowly sink to the ground. She looks at me and then turns, grabbing for something on her dresser. I hear her voice—very distant.

It's all fading away. I stare towards one wall. Hey, Erille has a dresser like mine. I see the blood-spattered room reflected in it, and a young man lying on top of a Demon's body, covered in blood.

He's me, but he's not me. The other Tom looks up.

He grins at me. A white devil dancing in a pool of crimson. He stares at me, and I think he winks for a second. His smile is like blood. But it's just

in my head. I turn from the mirror.

“It’s all in my head. All.”

Just me. Then throughout the castle I hear a ringing noise, like bells, and hear shouting, bells and shouting and a horn now, like a siren. I listen to the sounds, and hear him whispering in my head.

It’s not over Tom. Not over. Not yet.

“You’re just...just...”

Someone’s bent over me. Erille? She has a bottle in her hands and she’s pouring it over my chest. The world goes dark. But I can still hear him.

I’m as real as you are, Tom. I’m waiting for you to let me out. This was only the beginning.

And the devil laughs, and I smile. Because he’s not real.

He’s just in my head.

1.04 C

There were eight Demons, actually. The other six were waiting outside Isodore's room. They might have gotten her too, but my raising the alarm with the [Princess] saved her.

I learn that after I wake. That was still in Erille's bedroom, the floor and walls still splattered with my blood and that of the Demon soldiers. There is no young [Princess], though. Just a [Healer] tending to me and the Fool, several guards, and the two dead bodies.

Later, I can remember trying to sit up, feeling the pain which makes me almost scream, and the [Healer] telling me to lie still while the potions do their work. Soon, the pain becomes a memory, but ah, what a memory.

In this world it's possible to heal a wound in seconds where it would take months in my world. But the pain means that few people can stand to fight after taking such injuries. All but the best healing potions make you tired, sometimes nauseous—

And the agony of it can kill some people. The shock of it can stop a heart. I see the Fool convulsing as the [Healer] tends to him, crying out as his severed innards grow together and have to be pushed into his stomach before being healed.

But he is alive. And so is Erille. She is kept in a safe place, under highest guard while the entire palace and the rest of the city is put on high alert and searched. No other Demons are found, but watchful of more assassins, the Blighted King keeps his guards searching through the night and into the next day.

I don't get to see any of it. I sleep after being treated, sleep through the night and late into the day. When I get up later, head spinning, feeling at the unbroken skin on my stomach, I'm in a different room. Not mine, nor Erille's.

A grand room. And I am lying in a bed, a large, king-sized one. One with silk sheets. They're oddly a refreshing light green color for some reason, and the bed is complete with plush pillows which are also green and embroidered with gold threads.

That is my bed. The rest of my room holds a large table and chairs to sit around it, a private bathroom, a bookshelf with a few books on it, a side table on which a few bottles of precious-looking tonics or other potions are resting...and a lot more. In short, I wake up in richness.

I get up, wobbling, and feel my knees trembling like jelly. I pat at my stomach again, feel it whole, and then remember.

"I did it! I—"

I laugh, and then shake, feeling hot, then cold, and tremble at the memory of icy fear, of seeing the Demon with the bloody sword, of fighting —

But I did it. I killed them. And Erille.

She's alive. Right? And the Fool, I remember seeing him. But where are they? Not here, obviously. I need to ask.

I stumble to the doorway, then realize someone undressed me save for my underwear and pants earlier.

"Wait. Crap. This isn't my old underwear! Oh god."

Panicked, I have a crisis where the worst thought running through my head is that someone saw my private parts. Then I laugh and find some

clothes to wear. After all I've just been through, that's the least of my concerns.

I just really hope it wasn't a guy. Or wait—would a girl be worse? An old woman? A young woman? I imagine an old [Butler] having to strip me down and shudder. I really, really hope no one talked about what they saw.

I guess I'll find out soon enough.

“You may approach the throne.”

The voice echoes throughout the hall. It bounces off the black and white marble tiles, and from the ceiling where a series of intercrossing stone beams overhead hold up the rest of the palace. I'd look up, but I know that there are guards with bows and arrows and wands standing on the beams. Plus, I have to walk forwards.

So I do. I cross the distance to the twisted throne ahead of me. It sits on a dais, drawing every eye in the throne room. Those that aren't fixed on me, that is.

The Blighted King's throne. It is made of twisted ivory. The bones of some ancient monsters, carved into a huge seat and enchanted. Or maybe the magic is in the bones? The throne seems to shudder and grow as I walk towards it.

Just an illusion. But it makes the man sitting in the throne all the more foreboding because of it. I stare up at the Blighted King and remember how afraid of him I was the first time I saw him. Now I see an old man.

I kneel. The cold marble is hard on my knee, but that's protocol. The Blighted King studies me, and then bids me to rise. Around me, I see the

kneeling people getting to their feet.

The nobility, champions of the King, dignitaries, common people—that is to say, wealthy [Merchants] and servants and powerful individuals who aren't nobility or sworn to the crown—and my friends look at me. I stare towards the Blighted King and the three people who stand beside him on the throne.

The Blighted Queen, imperious, stone-faced. Isodore, looking pale, but pretty collected, and Erille, who half hides behind her step-sister, peering at me. She looks sideways, and I see a flash of color out of the corner of my eyes. The Fool stands, healed, watching me.

“Sir Thomas. The [Clown]. You have done our kingdom a great service this day. You protected our daughter, Princess Erille, when our guards failed us. Against assassins. *Demons*.”

The Blighted King's voice blazes with silent fury. The people around the room shift. I look up at him. I don't want to be here, but I was spirited to the throne room as soon as I left my room.

At least I'm not required to really say much unless asked. The people in the throne room watch me as I stand, awkward, gazing at the Blighted King's navel.

“*You* killed two assassins meant for my daughter.”

He says it like a question. The Blighted King stares at me.

“How?”

“I...had a knife, Your Majesty. I killed one Demon with that. And I took the other one's dagger.”

“You disarmed a soldier?”

“Yes, sire. I can steal things if I’m close enough. I can take a sword out of someone’s hands. It’s...well, a trick.”

“Show us.”

There’s a moment of hesitation, and then Nereshal strides forwards. He has a dagger in his hand, the metal of the blade tinted light purple. He holds it, and I gingerly grab it out of his hands. I don’t need to touch his hands or the blade to do it. I hear a quiet susurration, and hand the blade back to Nereshal, hilt-first. He accepts the blade. The Blighted King leans forwards a bit on his throne, eyes narrowing.

“Intriguing. A trick indeed. We saw it performed before, but it seemed paltry, then. What do you make of it, Nereshal?”

The time mage studies me for a moment, impassive. He doesn’t seem wary of me so much as...intrigued. Everyone’s giving me that look, really. I guess saving Erille makes me important again.

Crap.

The [Chronomancer] turns back to the Blighted King. He bows.

“It appears to be a Skill similar to a bag of holding, my King. The Fool can do the same. I have heard of other classes with similar skills. [Rangers] whose quivers can hold a seemingly endless number of arrows. Classes like [Thief] who can create secret containers about their person. I suppose these —[Clowns]—are known for the same feats?”

I think of improbably small clown cars, tricks with coins behind the ears, and a surplus of balloons for every occasion.

“Something like that, yeah.”

“A worthy Skill. Useful in battle. Tell me, Sir Tom. You claim to be no warrior, but you killed two elite Demon soldiers by yourself. Are [Clowns]

truly entertainers and not warriors as you claim? Do they not fight?”

The Blighted King stares at me. I want to laugh in his face. Sir Tom? A warrior? I’m just...no.

His question’s ridiculous, but he doesn’t know our world. So I take it seriously and think for a moment before replying.

Do clowns fight? What a question. Are you counting movie clowns who have supernatural abilities and eat kids, or do you mean real life ones? Even then, there are serial killer clowns...

Rodeo clowns are known for being badasses. Dante told me about it—he’s actually seen them dodging bulls in arenas. But an actual clown who fights for a living? I shake my head.

“No, Your Majesty. [Clowns] have tricks suited for combat, but they—aren’t warriors.”

The Blighted King looks at me, eyes boring into me. I return the gaze. He nods slowly.

“A pity. We search for Skills that might aid our people, classes that might be worth taking. It is a shame that this [Clown] class is not suited to war. But we understand more of your nature. We give you our thanks, Tom the [Clown].”

He inclines his head a fraction. I bow, prompted by Nereshal’s whisper. The Blighted King looks at me a moment longer, and then dismisses me from his thoughts again.

“We invite you to join our personage in the gardens shortly. We shall deliberate on a suitable reward tonight. Now onto more pressing matters. Nereshal, summon the commander of the palace guard. Failure must be met with appropriate punishment.”

Like that, I'm ushered out of the throne room. I walk away as another man, pale and sweating, takes my place. Some of the people in the room disperse, and once we're outside and the massive doors to the room have swung shut, I hear them cheering.

I wish they wouldn't. But I'm still glad. My friends cluster around me, slapping me on the back, congratulating me. For killing the Demons? For being sane while doing it? I don't know. I don't really care. I'm happy enough for the praise, whatever the reason.

After that, I go to the gardens for lunch. I was dragged before the Blighted King before I could get anything to eat and I am *starving*.

Politics. Intrigue. Wait, are those the same words? They're here even in Rhir, in the Blighted Kingdom. People vie to become the most important person, the most valuable asset to the Blighted King, or to control more power. Naturally, my friends and I are all small fry, but again, saving a [Princess] is usually a big deal no matter where you go.

That's probably why I got the fancy new room. Richard, Emily, and the others certainly didn't get an upgrade. And that's also why I was invited to the gardens. Again, no one else from my group was. And finally, that's how I end up sitting with a bunch of the nobility of Rhir, listening to them gossip and talk over matters of the realm while the Fool performs for their children, some mages display illusions, and a [Bard] plays soft music in the background.

I don't care. I'm here for the food. The servants offer me a cut of meat from a weird, long tongue. I take it and chew the soft meat without a

second's thought. It resists in my mouth for a second, then it's soft, juicy. Succulent. I'm too hungry to quibble about the tongue bit.

“—Naturally we must retaliate in kind. I am not debating that point, Lord Yebior. But I assert that it would be a mistake to use [Assassins].”

There's a light debate raging at the moment. I'm sitting in a circle of about sixteen nobles, one of many groups in the gardens. Others are strolling about, talking, and the Blighted King has his own group, of course. Since I have bad allergies, I'm staying as far away from the flowers and whatnot as possible. The people around me are some form of important, and my only input to the conversation has been to nod when everyone else does.

The woman who's speaking is Lady Zekyria, wearing a pink and red outfit that looks a lot more practical than the dress I saw her in last time. As in, you could probably run in this one without tripping. It's a cross between a riding dress and trousers, which looks great on her. I try not to stare.

Red. It's the color she's wearing, as is her sister who sits next to her, chewing on some tongue, and quite a few other ladies in the gathering. It appears as a splash of color whenever I see it.

Miscarriages. I wonder if the corruption on Rhir causes it? But Lady Zekyria is fierce, even in mourning.

“It is a fact that Rhir cannot field the same quality of [Assassins] as other continents. Purely because there is no Assassin's Guild in our nation. Infighting of that sort is too detrimental, of course, but it leaves us with a deficit of such killers in moments like these.”

Lord Yebior, a big guy with a beard and a scimitar at his hip, frowns. I take a plum tart from a plate and bite into it. Yum. I wonder what he's gonna say? I have no idea.

“I don’t disagree, Lady Zekyria. However, how else would we send a message to the Demon King other than by stealth? I am not proposing we send low-level [Assassins] either—but surely we could contract the Assassin’s Guild on another continent?”

“For a suicide mission into Demon territory? And to send one of their best across the sea? Assuming it could be done, think of the *cost!*”

Zekyria scoffs openly and I nod along with some of the others. Good point. Hey, is that a fruit drink I see being served? I could use a glass.

“And what do you think your reward from His Majesty will be, Sir Tom?”

A voice speaks and I nearly jump out of my skin. A [Lady] leans over to me, elegant, eyes on my face. I start sweating as I realize I’ve lost track of the conversation.

“Me? I uh...I have no idea. I don’t really need a reward.”

The others make polite scoffing sounds. Lady Zekyria tosses back her hair, which makes me sweat harder. Beautiful women talking to me is not a normal occurrence, and all the women around me are [Ladies]. Steady on, Tom.

“Surely there is something you desire? The Blighted King’s gifts are no trifles. I imagine he might present you with a dagger from his armory, perhaps a powerful artifact? Do you have a preference for enchantments, Sir Tom? I’ve always been a fan of ward enchantments myself, but for a knife specialist, perhaps you prefer contact enchantments?”

I stare at her blankly. What *is* it with people in this nation? The nobles are bloodthirsty. I guess being at war for thousands of years makes this kind of thinking normal. I cough.

“I’m not an expert at uh, enchantments. All of my knives are non-magical.”

“What? Then you surely need better equipment. All of the King’s champions have artifacts of their own—I shall petition His Majesty that you be awarded a blade worthy of your accomplishments tonight!”

“What? No, that’s really...I wouldn’t want to take a valuable weapon. Not when someone else might need it, you know?”

The others laugh. Lord Yebior gives me a pitying look.

“Sir Tom, His Majesty has enough arms to outfit an army. He has opened his armory in the past in times of need, but in safer times...it is an honor to receive an artifact from his vaults, not a burden, I assure you.”

“Oh? There’s a lot of artifacts?”

“Of course! This is *Rhir*, after all. We have accumulated treasures for generations. Each champion is accorded items worthy of any Named Adventurer if they did not have one already. Consider Sir Hesserass, over there. The Naga. You see him? He holds the Battleaxe of Caxel. A fascinating weapon—if held, the blade doubles in size but swings as fast as any hatchet. And Lord Meliore? The Shortsword of Weeping. Poisoned, obviously, which is why he has to keep it sheathed at all times. But my favorite artifact is perhaps the King’s own blade, Blightbane, which has several enchantments. I haven’t seen it drawn in years, but it is a sight...”

Lord Yebior begins talking enthusiastically about the artifacts around him, the others chiming in their examples. I blink and stare from person to person in the gathering. And *I’m* going to get a weapon like that? Well...it would be cool.

One of the people in the gathering is the old woman who dueled Richard earlier. When I ask about what she got, the others laugh. Zekyria

leans over to me and whispers.

“Before she became a [Marchioness], Lady Xersia was known far and wide as a Named Adventurer. She was called Xersia the Scorpion. She has her own spear—I believe she was gifted with an amulet from the treasury for her service.”

“Oh. Named Adventurers can become nobility?”

Zekyria looks puzzled.

“Naturally! For their services against the enemy, famous adventurers are often granted lands and wealth. It is one of the things that draws them here. Alas, we lose them to age or battle too frequently.”

I look over at the old woman. She’s happily chewing on a tart. I don’t think she has many teeth.

“She looked pretty good when she was dueling the others last night.”

Zekyria sighs.

“A Named Adventurer never loses their Skills, of course, but age *is* a limiting factor. Lady Xersia can only fight at her best for a few minutes before tiring, which is why she seldom returns to the front. If only Lord Nereshal could halt the aging of multiple individuals in our realm...”

“Does he do it for only the Blighted King?”

“Him, and perhaps the Queen. I believe Nereshal uses the spell on himself, but his mana may not extend beyond that.”

The [Lords] and [Ladies] nod. One of them clears his throat.

“Speaking of warriors, Sir Thomas, Her Majesty was a famed warrior on the battlefield before she became the Blighted Queen. No doubt it was one of the reasons why His Majesty was so enamored with her.”

I glance at the Blighted Queen. I can imagine her smashing someone over the head with a mace. Yup, yup. Next to Zekyria, her sister, Lady Theras sighs longingly, her eyes on her King.

“Ah, if only I had become a [Lady] suited to the battlefield, rather than the manor...far better to die with a sword in hand rather than waste away in old age.”

“There’s many uses for your Skills outside of battle.”

Zekyria reassures her twin, smiling. Yebior nods.

“A warrior is not all that is needed in service of the realm. Consider the role the Lady Reinhart occupies in her lands for instance...”

Theras scoffs openly.

“The Flower of Izril? Hah! That brazen hussy—”

Zekyria tsks softly.

“She’s an ally of the kingdom, Theras. Remember that.”

“Nominally. She’d be far better off halting her squabbles for power with the Drakes and sending support *here*. But her complacency is costing her. Did you know I heard she was being targeted by [Assassins]?”

“Surely not. I’d heard they were under her thumb.”

“So you might think. But it seems her manor was attacked. Now I don’t know the details, of course...”

The talk turns towards some woman I’ve never heard about. I settle back into my chair, and hear a cheer going up. I look over and see the young children gathering around the Fool, who’s just performed a triple backflip, much to their amazement. I see heads turning, and the faces of the nobles around me are pursed with disapproval at the break in decorum.

“Tactless as usual. I suppose the Fool is recovered if he can move around like that...”

“A waste of a healing potion if you ask me. Why use such high-quality items on him?”

“He *is* a guest of the palace and entertains Her Highness. Still...I can understand given his level, but a [Fool] is nonetheless a fool, is he not?”

“His level? Is the Fool...a high-level?”

“One would imagine so, but his performances are usually decidedly lacking.”

Theras sniffs and the other nobles seem to agree. Zekyria explains as she eyes the Fool juggling twelve balls this time. As if that’s *easy*.

“Before he came to Rhir and pledged himself to His Majesty, the [Fool] was a noted entertainer who travelled across Baleros and Terandria, putting on performances. There are tales of the grand feats he would perform. However, these days he seems content to entertain children. Worthwhile, of course, for Her Highness’ sake, but if he cannot even repay his debt to our king with his life...”

I cough, feeling obliged to defend the Fool.

“He was taken hostage, right? And he tried to warn me when the Demons attacked.”

There’s not much sympathy from the others. Zekyria tosses her head dismissively.

“His injuries are, of course, regrettable. Still, he would do well to learn from your example, Sir Tom. You two are akin, are you not? But he was taken prisoner while *you* fought. Most admirable.”

Is she...hitting on me? She leans over and I do my best not to edge away. I know Zekyria has a husband. She had a kid. But I'm getting a vibe—then again, I'm not good with picking things up. But it seems like—

I'm saved from any thoughts in that direction by an interruption. The people around me rise and I hastily get to my feet as none other than Erille and Isodore approach. We all bow as the [Princesses] stop before me.

“Sir Tom.”

Isodore's voice is polite and her smile appears genuine. But it's probably fake. She nods towards me, and Erille.

“Erille wished to thank you personally for saving her life yesterday.”

She nudges her sister, and Erille steps forward. Her hands are in her dress, and she twists them together nervously. She looks up at me, and mumbles.

“...you.”

I can't hear the first part of the sentence. Erille curtseys quickly, looking upset at being the focus of all this attention. I see the Fool grimace as he stands, juggling across the garden. He's watching her sadly. I bow towards Erille, not wanting to draw out the moment.

“I'm honored to serve, Princess Erille.”

She nods at me and then flees. Isodore curtseys quickly and follows her. I hear a sigh from the other nobles.

“So young.”

“It was a stroke of fortune that the Demons did not kill her, truly. I fear she has so many years to grow, though.”

“Lady Isodore is promising, if young. A few years and she might...”

Zekyria turns to me with a bright smile.

“I’m sure Princess Erille is truly grateful. And perhaps we shall learn what reward will be bestowed on you tonight? I would be most grateful to sit with you at the banquet.”

“Ah! Lady Zekyria, I would put myself for the same honor!”

Yebior interrupts. The other nobles turn and begin fighting over me like one of the snacks. I try to excuse myself. Jeeze. Save a [Princess] and suddenly everyone’s your friend.

I wait for a reply in my head and hear none. I smile.

After more conversation, more talk and eating and a good deal of time, it’s late in the evening. Just before dinner, which makes me regret eating so much in the gardens. But I can get away at last for a little bit before then, so I make a beeline to my room. There’s something I have to do.

I get lost on the way. I went back to my old room before Richard reminded me where I’m staying now. He grins at me as I throw up my hands.

“It’s a gift, Tom. You should enjoy your new place.”

“I guess. Is anyone else upset? I don’t want them to think I’m asking for special treatment. I could ask the King or Nereshal...”

Richard shakes his head.

“Emily’s salty, but we all know you deserve it. Besides, we can’t complain. And you did nearly die.”

“I guess. I’ll see you at dinner, then? I’m supposed to sit with some of the nobles, but I think I can get away.”

I turn to go. Richard stops me.

“Hey Tom.”

“What?”

“You did it. You saved a [Princess]. And you did it...without having a problem, right?”

He looks at me. I look back and nod, slowly.

“Yeah. I guess I did.”

His grip tightens a bit on my shoulder. Richard smiles.

“I’m glad.”

I smile as well and walk away without another word. It takes me twenty minutes to find my rooms, and they’re not that far away in the palace. So many corridors and so far to walk...you could get all your exercise just going from one part of the castle to another. When I finally get to my door, I walk in, a bit tired, elated, and collapse onto the mattress, thinking of a nap.

But my eyes are drawn to one thing in the room besides the bed. The dresser. It’s much like the one in my old room and is, in fact, decorated with my possessions from my old room as well. I stare at the perfect mirror and get out of bed to hobble over to it. I touch my fingers to the cool glass and stare into my eyes.

“I win.”

The Tom in the mirror doesn’t respond. After a minute he raises his hand. I press it against the glass.

“I killed them. Me. It was...I had to do it. And it was terrible and it hurt. But it was *me*, get it? I did that. Me.”

I finish speaking, stare at myself. I stare back, looking a bit tired, a bit triumphant. I wait, but I don't reply.

“I won't be afraid of you anymore. I won't listen. You're in my head. You're a part of me. But you don't control me. I control myself, and I've taken responsibility for my actions.”

At last, he stirs. The other Tom looks into my eyes, and his lips grudgingly move.

“Keep telling yourself that.”

“I will.”

“Shut up, you idiot. You don't know anything. You killed two Demons and everyone's praising your name. But you know you're not in the clear yet, don't you?”

I stare as Tom steps back a bit. My hands go up; he adjusts his shirt.

“It's not over. Do you really think it is? Don't be stupid, Thomas. I might be insane, but I'm *not* an idiot. Neither are you.”

“What do you mean?”

He stares at me, and then walks out of the mirror's range. I sit on the bed, hearing his voice, my voice, in my ears.

“Think about it. Demon soldiers, appearing in the middle of the night? How? And they just so happen to know where the [Princesses] are sleeping? That's hard to do, even for assassins. If they were assassins.”

I remember seeing the dead guard outside of Erille's room and shudder.

“They seemed pretty intent on killing to me.”

I feel my eyes roll.

“Yes. I guess they did. All two of them. And there were six for the other princess. None for the Blighted King, his Queen, or anyone else. Why’s that?”

No response. I get back up, go back to the mirror. Tom stares at me. The black pits of his eyes are dark. Fathomless. I look away.

Someone organized my belongings, such as they are. I glance down at my tin of grease paint, play with the freshly laundered clown suit as he talks.

“This is just the start. You know that. And you might have killed two Demons, but you know you’re nothing without me.”

“I’m *me*. You’re in my head. And you can’t control me. I proved that just now. Yesterday, I mean.”

“Oh yeah?”

He laughs. I look up and glare at him in the mirror. He glares back, and then grins. And then the grin freezes. It slides off my face and I study myself. I shake my head.

“It’s all me. See?”

I wait. The reflection doesn’t respond. I go on.

“Me. I pretend. I get it now. I’m doing this. And I can stop. It’s my choice. Maybe I like thinking I’m insane. But I’m not. And if I don’t let you have a thing, you can stay a voice in my head for all I care.”

No response. I smile bitterly.

“Good chat. Let’s never do this again. I win. No—there was never anyone to play against, was there? Just me.”

I turn. I hear no voice, no mocking reply. It is just me.

Then I hear a whisper in my head.

So you say. I left a little present for you, though. A little reminder I'm here. Want me to tell you what it is?

I ignore the voice. Turn. What's the old expression again? Sticks and stones can break my bones, but words...

Words can hurt. Of course they can. And thoughts can be terrible. But they will not control me.

It's time for the banquet. I absently get ready in front of the mirror. I don't have many good pairs of clothes, but I do make sure I have a few knives up my sleeves. Just in case.

And then I go. Voiceless. I stride out of the bedroom, feeling better than I have in months. A new room, a friend in the Fool, and some measure of respect. And who knows? Maybe things can get better than this. I don't know, but I'm hopeful.

I might just enjoy tonight after all.

I get lost on the way to the banquet hall again. It's my new room. Plus, I never got to know the old one that well. It's also hard to get directions. All the servants just stare at me and point. I guess they still don't think I'm that much of a hero. I know I'm not.

But I still get to the banquet hall in good time. The [Chamberlain] blinks when he sees me, but points me to the table with my friends.

I sense heads turning as I enter the room. People watching me, murmuring. I hate that. But I also know that they'll stop as soon as something else happens. Give me a week, a month, and people will barely remember my name, let alone call me a hero.

My friends are sitting with their backs to me, laughing with the Drakes. I know I should sit with the nobles, but I want to talk to them first, say hi. Maybe ask if Lady Zekyria has a husband. I dunno, I'm feeling very lucky. Although that's probably pushing any amount of luck I'd ever have.

"Hey guys. What's up?"

They turn, laughing, at the sound of my voice. Then freeze. Richard pauses, a cup halfway to his mouth. Emily turns pale. Keith and Eddy nearly fall out of their seats. And Cynthia—

Screams.

The sound cuts through every other noise in the banquet hall. It's pure, genuine terror. I see guards start to run towards us, and sense every eye on me. But why?

"Cynthia? What's wrong?"

I take a step towards her. She backs out of her seat, hand knocking away plates, dishes—she tries to climb over the table to get away from me. I stop and turn towards Eddy. He's shrinking back in his seat. And then Richard—he has a hand on his sword. His face is white as he stares at me.

"Tom?"

It's a whisper. And suddenly, my heart's pounding. Why is he looking at me like that? Why is he looking at me like—

"Richard? Why are you all staring at me?"

He looks shocked. Tongue-tied. Unable to explain. He looks at Emily and she breaks the silence.

“Tom. Your face.”

I slowly raise my hands to my face. Uncomprehending. Then I touch my cheeks. Feel a bit of oil, sticky slickness blended with a powder. I stare at my fingers and see white.

“A mirror.”

I look around. Faces, staring. The world blurs. I lunge for the table and people draw back around me. Cynthia screams again. But I just want to see.

There’s a plate holding some grapes. I dump them off and hold up the shiny surface, polishing it with one hand. Why—why is my sleeve *yellow*? What am I wearing?

And then I see. Then I hear laughter in my head, and feel the world *shift*.

A clown stares back at me. Face pale and white, eyebrows drawn in black. Shadows under the eyes. A red nose. A crimson splash. And red lips, just waiting to smile. The clown stares back, horrified, dressed in a bright yellow suit, splashed with faint stains the best washing couldn’t remove.

A clown. And then I turn, and see the horror on my friends’ faces. The confusion, the look of unease on the others. The guests of the Blighted King have seen the Fool, but they’ve never seen a [Clown]. Never seen a man who dresses himself up to mock the world like I do.

And I feel the floor breaking up underneath me. I didn’t know. I thought I was getting ready. I didn’t—

Is he real? Am I insane?

No. This is just—

“It’s just me, guys. I—sorry.”

I back away from the others. Richard’s still staring. Cynthia’s sobbing. Some of them are just staring at me, nervous. Others...some of them saw me afterwards, laughing. They’re the ones who look truly frightened.

I walk away from them, hearing Richard try to explain to the guards what made Cynthia scream, sensing conversation resume in the room. But the eyes follow me.

What could I say to them? What can I say? This was a joke? No. That I didn’t realize I’d put on my costume and the paint? That’s worse.

I don’t know if I should stay. But as I’m debating running for the doors and burning the costume and washing myself, I hear someone call out.

“Sir Tom!”

Lady Zekyria. She’s waving to me. She doesn’t appear to be bothered by my appearance. She laughs as I walk over to her.

“What a look! And what entertainment, Sir Tom! Is that what a [Clown] is supposed to look like? You’re far more diverting than a [Fool]!”

“Indeed.”

Sir Yebior sits across from me, eying me appraisingly. He gestures for me to sit. Dreaming, walking in a nightmare, I do.

It’s like I’m in one of those dreams where I go to school and realize I’m naked. Only this time, no one at the table cares. They joke about it, asking why I scared Cynthia so, listening to my garbled explanation with polite smiles. They don’t know.

But I do. I feel cold certainty gripping me at last.

I am not in control.

What can I do? What should I do? I stare towards the head table. The Blighted King is watching me. He's supposed to present me with a reward, right? I don't want it. I need to leave, to find somewhere alone to think—

How angry will he be if I leave now? How rude would that be? I don't care. The nobility are laughing around me. I go to push out my chair. And stop.

“Demons are attacking!”

A man screams the word. I turn, the world slows. I see a soldier, armor covered in blood, one arm hanging limp, running into the hall, shoving aside the [Chamberlain]. Again there is silence. He rushes towards the Blighted King's table, blocked by a wall of guards who rush towards him. He stops there, and the Blighted King rises.

“Where?”

“The courtyard, Your Majesty! They appeared out of nowhere. A spell—they're invading the palace and securing the courtyard as we speak!”

I hear screams now, but the Blighted King is on his feet and another man with a greatsword leaps up and roars for silence. He and four other warriors, including Xersia the Scorpion, race out of the hall, their forms a blur.

“Nereshal!”

The King shouts one word. The [Chronomancer] runs across the hall and two other mages, a female Centaur and a male half-Elf, run over. Nereshal raises his hand and speaks a word.

A picture floats in the air, clearer than any video, large enough so that I can see it from where I sit. I see the courtyard from above, dark, melting snow covering parts of the flagstone. And dark shapes, hundreds of them, streaming towards the palace. More still hold the gates while others race

along the courtyard walls, swords flashing as they cut down the guards stationed there.

Demons.

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“How did they appear?”

There’s chaos in the banquet hall. The Blighted King is questioning the guard who raised the alarm. Other soldiers are rushing for the doors, creating blockades in the corridors. But most of the guards and people are staying put. Waiting. Listening.

Fear is in the air. My stomach is churning. What can I do? What should I do?

He was right. I was right. But how did the Demons get here?

“Teleportation magic. A scroll—possibly artifacts. To teleport so many, the Demon King must have used every magical item in his possession.”

Nereshal is conferring with a group of [Mages]. His eyes are on the projection. And then I see movement from the courtyard.

The Demons are streaming into the castle, most through the main gates. But they’re also moving along the battlements. One group is clustered around the left wall. I see an explosion, and a different group appears.

Humans. Two Humans, a man and an old woman. A Gnoll, and a Selphid. They cut down the Demons and charge into the courtyard, running along the battlements. The Blighted King’s champions.

A cheer goes up through the room as the people see the four champions charging the Demons. But the Blighted King and his advisors don’t cheer. They watch, intently, as the four warriors rush a group in the center of the courtyard.

“There. Their leader is a mage.”

Nereshal points. A female Demon wearing robes is standing in the courtyard, staff aloft. By her side is a male Demon, holding a bow taller than he is. It must be seven feet tall. He wears no armor. One of the champions raises his own bow, draws an arrow, looses it in a moment.

The arrow vanishes before it reaches the Demon with the bow. He puts an arrow to his bow, draws, fires. The Gnoll who fired tries to dodge, but the arrow *curves* in the air and strikes him in the chest. He falls.

Lady Xersia, a man with a shortsword, and the Selphid holding two greatswords are left. They charge into a group of Demons coming up the stairs. The Selphid impales two on each sword; the Demons run *into* the blades. He disappears, covered by the Demons who don't flinch as Xersia and the man with the short sword cut them down one by one.

“Fearless.”

Nereshal speaks the word like a curse. More of the Demons are flooding towards the two champions. The man with the shortsword dodges left—an arrow slashes his leg. The Demon with the bow puts another arrow in the air, and I see it pierce through the man's armor as if it weren't there.

“Magic-piercing arrows.”

The Blighted Queen speaks. Silence reigns. Xersia is last. The old woman dashes towards the Demon with the bow like lightning across the ground. The Demon puts an arrow to his bow and looses it. She curves around the arrow like lightning. She lunges with her spear—

And vanishes. Everyone stares at the image of the courtyard. The Blighted King turns to Nereshal.

“What happened?”

“The [Mage] is specialized in teleportation magic.”

The time mage speaks quietly. His eyes are fixed on the projection in the air. The Blighted Queen looks around the courtyard.

“Where was she sent?”

“Up.”

A shape, tumbling down through the air. Thousands of feet overhead, falling like a comet. Tiny, still clutching her spear.

Xersia.

She falls out of the sky. The Blighted King, the people in the banquet hall, everyone, watch in silence as Lady Xersia hits the ground. She threw her spear at the end—the Demon with the bow shoots it out of the sky.

The Blighted King watches it all, as the two, the teleportation [Mage] and the Demon [Archer], calmly turn back to their business. The [Mage] raises her staff and seems to chant. The [Archer] takes a position on the wall and begins shooting down towards the city.

“Unforgivable.”

The Blighted King’s voice is cold. Nereshal studies the projection, and I see more of the Demons, the Fearless, streaming into the castle. Hundreds of them. The time mage turns to his King, face grave.

“I know the archer, Your Majesty. And the mage. They are both high-level, thought to be over Level 40 at the least. The Demon King has sent two of his best warriors to hold this ground. One to protect, the other to open a gate.”

“And let his army pour through. Nereshal, how long do we have?”

All eyes are on the [Chronomancer] as he thinks. He turns to confer with the Centaur [Mage], and then raises his voice.

“Teleportation spells are exceedingly complex. Assuming the mage knows where she wants to open a portal to, and her Skills are focused in that area...anywhere from two hours to forty minutes.”

“You are sure? Could they not speed up the spell if they were prepared? I have seen you teleport short distances within minutes.”

The Blighted Queen has a long mace, black like obsidian, in her hand. She rests the head on the ground as she looks at Nereshal. He nods.

“Any competent mage can teleport short distances relatively quickly, but a portal hundreds of miles or more away? Your Majesty, no [Mage] in the world could perform such calculations in ten minutes or less. Not even an Archmage. However, she should not be able to cast such spells at all! The anti-teleportation ward—”

“—Is clearly not working. We have less than an hour, then. We must repel the Fearless invading the palace. They surely seek the Blighted King’s head. And the [Mage] must die.”

The Blighted Queen is full of action, ready to move out. The King is deliberate. He looks at Nereshal.

“Why is the ward stone not working, Nereshal? Find me answers. Until then, if the teleportation spell is not working, is it possible to send a force to deal with the [Mage]? Ambush her?”

Nereshal hesitates.

“We lack warriors on the level of the two in the courtyard, Your Majesty. Lady Xersia was the highest-level warrior present. I could attempt to battle myself with Her Majesty, but—”

“If we lose you, we step one moment closer to the end. As for our consort—no.”

The Blighted Queen turns to her husband.

“With respect, my lord, if we fail to repel the Demons, all is lost.”

“Then we shall consider it a matter of last resort.”

He nods. The Blighted King rises, and turns to a [Strategist] at his side. They confer out loud.

“It seems we must push back the Demons instead. I will use my Skills, but it falls to you and the other warriors present in the palace to push back their line.”

“It will be difficult, my King.”

A Dullahan with a scar down her face grimaces, her face set. She brings out a map and spreads it out on the table.

“Defensively, we could hold these halls and wear down a superior force over the course of days, or barricade ourselves in for weeks. But with a second force on the way, we must retake the castle and the courtyard within the hour. And the soldiers flooding the castle are elites. The Fearless have been sent in numbers. We will fight them to the death.”

The Blighted King curses.

“They struck us at our weakest moment! How did the Demon King know? If we must take the courtyard, it will be numbers against those two. Their levels will create a slaughter. For the army we need, we must rally the guards. Where are they stationed? Who in this room can fight? Act quickly; we have little time.”

The Blighted King turns, and like that the spell of paralysis on the room breaks. Men and women rush towards the doors, some dashing out of them, others barricading entrances. Richard and Emily are on their feet, and they rush towards the Blighted King with the other people with combat classes.

The rest of the people in the room, noncombatants, talk, afraid. Some are weeping; I can see the Fool standing with Erille and Isodore, their faces pale.

At my table, the [Lords] and [Ladies] are speaking urgently. Yebior rises to his feet, unsheathing a dagger from his belt.

“Time to fight, my friends. If we can put but a single body between the Demons and our King—”

He strides towards the gathering warriors with a few [Lords]. Zekyria turns to the others and pulls something off her finger. A ring, the gem glowing with an inner light.

“We have artifacts. Let us gather them for the warriors. Come now, hold nothing back.”

A flurry of motion breaks out. I look around the table and feel lost. Afraid.

What can I do? Fight? I’m no warrior, but—everyone’s needed. I should volunteer. Or I could stay, keep them safe if it comes to the worst. Richard’s there, face grim, and so is Emily, Eddy, Vincent—they’re all ready to fight and die. I should be too.

I go to stand up. I put my hands on the table and stand.

My legs don’t move. I stare. Blink. I try again. My legs don’t move.

I look down. Or try to. My head doesn’t move. I’m telling it to look, to move, but it doesn’t. I try to raise my hands. Nothing happens.

Nothing works. I can’t even blink. What’s going on? I can’t—I’ve lost control of my body.

My hand rises. I stare at it as I pick up a fork. And then my head does turn. It stares left, towards a silver pitcher filled with wine. The metal is

clear and polished, it reflects my face. A clown stares back at me, face painted, dressed in a ludicrous costume stained with blood. And then, to my horror, he grins at me.

“Well, it seems like everything’s going wrong, doesn’t it? My turn to come out, I think.”

No. No. Oh, no, no, no, no, *no*—not now. This can’t be happening. Slowly, the hand with the fork rises. In the mirror, Tom twirls it, as the people around him panic and more screams begin to echo through the hall.

“We had a lot of fun, didn’t we, Tom? When you thought I wasn’t real, when you were so *sure* that you’d beaten me? As if you could beat yourself.”

This isn’t real. This isn’t happening. I can’t be going insane. Not now! I tried so hard! I didn’t let you out!

I can’t speak. I’m only a voice in his head. In my head. Tom laughs, and it’s not my laughter. It’s darker, wilder, with an edge of madness in it.

“Let me out? You can’t *let me out*, you idiot! There’s nothing to let out! You and I are the same. How can you stop yourself? See?”

He lifts the fork and begins to pick at his teeth with it, casually. I try to stop him, to seize control of my hand.

You’re not me! You’re something else! Give me back my body—

“Tom, Tom!”

He raises his voice. I can sense Zekyria turning her head to stare at him. Me. Tom ignores the look. I ignore the look. I look into my reflection’s eyes, see the panicked look there. Hah. I hate him so much, that other me. I speak to him.

“It’s always been you, Tom. There’s no one in here but you. And me. Heh. Haha.”

I giggle. I hear his voice.

You can’t do this. The Demons are attacking. We need to help. We need

“Need?”

I cut him off, harshly. I spin, pointing around the room. The Blighted King has lost control. His warriors are gathered around him as he, Nereshal, and a few advisors plot feverishly. The view of the courtyard has shifted. Now I see inner corridors of the castle. It’s a maze, but the Fearless are flooding down it, cutting down servants, fighting pockets of guards.

“Do you think they have a chance? Really, Tom? They’re doomed, unless someone helps them. And we both know you’re not the man for the job.”

Don’t. You can’t!

“Can’t I?”

I raise my voice, lift the delicate fork up. People are shouting, asking their King what they should do. He’s trying to get them to shut up. What a poor [King]! Can’t he see the truth?

Stop! I won’t let you cause a massacre again! I won’t! I’d rather die!

“Sir Tom? What are you doing?”

Now Lady Zekyria is looking at me. I grin at her. She likes me. I wonder if she’ll like me after this?

Don’t hurt her!

“Sir Tom? Are you going to fight? I believe you are needed.”

Yebior is calling out to the Blighted King. Idiot.

“My King, what should I—”

Stop! STOP!

Voices. So many voices! Too many. I raise the fork high overhead and bring it down. Onto my other hand.

“Enough!”

The tines of the fork go through my hand and hit bone. The voice in my head shuts up. I hear it scream and fade. And the room goes silent. I stand, and yank the fork out of my hand. I stare at the bent tines and try to fix one. Disappointing.

“They don’t make them like they used to. Hey there!”

The Blighted King is looking at me! I stroll over, laughing as I see his guards raising their weapons and looking uncertainly at me. I raise my hands.

“Pardon me, Your Majesty. Sorry for the interruption, but I needed your attention.”

“[Clown]. What do you want?”

He stares at me. I smile at him.

“Just a word, old man. By the way, I don’t think we’ve met. I’m *Tom*. Pleased to meet you.”

I stick my hand in his face. He recoils. What? Oh, that’s the bloody one. How rude. The Blighted Queen hisses.

“How *dare* you?”

The Blighted King raises a hand, staring at me uncertainly.

“I know who you are.”

“No, you don’t.”

I wag a finger at the King and point to my chest.

“You see, you met Tom. I’m *Tom*. The same, but different. Better. I tell jokes. He’s one big, fat joke. And he’s taking a break so I can come out.”

“Tom—”

Richard. He pales as I swing around, grinning at him. Emily backs up.

“*Richard!* Hey, we never got a chance to talk. I’d love to chat, but I’m a bit busy. If you could just hold on—”

“We are wasting time. Remove him. Guards.”

Nereshal looks at me. Ooh, *he’s* not bothered by me at all, I can tell. I trip up the first guard who comes towards me and throw my arm around the time mage. He stiffens, but doesn’t throw me off. Maybe because of the dagger I have pressed against his throat? Now I have everyone’s attention.

“Good! I don’t want to be a bother, Mister Important Blighted Guy, but I just wanted to point something out. You’re all hot and bothered about this Demon army that appeared, but did anyone think to ask how they got here?”

Nereshal shifts. I push the dagger into his throat and he stops moving his hand oh-so-stealthily up.

“Teleportation magic—”

“Yeah, yeah. We *got* that the first time, old man. What I mean is, how’d they get past your special teleportation blocker? You were talking about it all day.”

“I do not know. It is *here*, but it isn’t working.”

Nereshal turns his head and I stare at a younger [Mage] holding a stone in his hands. I grin. All the pieces are falling into place! Just like that.

“Well, well. That makes sense. Hey, Your Majesty. Wanna know something funny?”

The Blighted King stares at me.

“Release Nereshal, [Clown].”

“No, *no*, that’s not the important bit. The knife is—whoops, sorry, scratched you there, didn’t I? Ignore me. Focus on the big picture. I know who let the Demons in.”

Everyone stares at me, an audience of suckers waiting for the punchline. I grin. The Blighted Queen leans forward.

“Who?”

“Him.”

I let go of Nereshal to point across the room. It’s obvious, of course. Everything pointed to him, but Tom was too stupid to put the pieces together. Good thing I’m as smart as he is. Just as ugly, though.

The Fool stops in his tracks, one hand on the door, the other holding Princess Erille’s hand. He turns. I laugh at him.

“Where are you *going*, Fool? Don’t you want to meet your buddies?”

He looks at me. I wink. The Fool looks around the room. What’s he going to do? He could probably pass it off, pretend he was trying to get Erille to safety, call me mad (which is totally fair), but—oh, no, he’s running!

He nearly makes it out of the door. I think he would have, and with Erille too, if good old Neres didn’t get up and point at the Fool. He freezes

in place, one hand flinging the door wide. Time stopped.

“See? Only the guilty run. And idiots. And joggers. The worst of all.”

I laugh as soldiers charge at the Fool. The Blighted King stares at him as the Fool is dragged over.

“Fool?”

“Aw, don’t look so surprised. It was bound to happen. Bad parenting, poor leadership, probably some evil crime the Fool found out about, maybe he thinks he’s her real father. You certainly do a bad job of it, don’t you?”

I sling an arm around the Blighted King and watch him tense up. Hah! I laugh and plant a kiss on his cheek, and spin away. Someone puts a sword to my throat. The Blighted King stares at me.

“How did you know?”

“I’m smart. Hey, nice sword.”

I grab it from the guard and watch as he recoils. Aha! The Blighted Queen lifts her mace. I toss the sword down.

“Oh hush, it was only a *kiss*. Don’t get all jealous on me now. Anyways, Your Majesty, that explains it all. The Fool marked the spot in the courtyard for his buddies to come through, tried to abduct the [Princesses] beforehand —”

“But how did he disable the teleportation ward? It’s right here—”

Nereshal strides over to a glowing stone. I stare at it.

“Pretty. Also: fake.”

“Impossible.”

I kick him in the groin. What? He was asking for it and it's funny. Nereshal goes white. I pick up the stone from where he dropped it and lift the glowing thing into the air. Sparkly. It's like a glowing purple...stone. You know what? I'm not good with pictures. I drop the stone and stomp on it.

It breaks. Again, there's the entire 'bladed weapons raised', but I decide to ignore it. The Blighted King stares down at the stone. The fragments disappear as he watches.

"What is this?"

"It's fake. The [Fool] made it. It's a Skill of his. Try to keep up. I don't know how he *got* it, but I suppose that's your fault, hmm?"

I glance at Nereshal as he bends over, clutching at his unmentionables. You would have thought his fancy robes would have been spelled to protect him against *that*. The [Mage] glares at me.

"I should kill you—"

"Nereshal. Enough. This—Tom has given us the answers. Restrain the Fool. I wish to question him afterwards. But we must repel the Demons. *Now.*"

The Blighted King whirls away from me. I laugh. He turns back. Oh, now he's getting upset. I'd kiss him again, but he's too far away.

"What?"

I stroll towards him and a big mace blocks my way. I stare at the Blighted Queen and then lick her arm. She backhands me.

"Ow."

I think she knocked a tooth out! Wait—yes she did. I get up, laughing, and see the faces. Oh, the *faces*. They're all staring at me. Some shocked,

others horrified—the way I like it.

Who says I'm not a people person?

“Sorry. Pardon *me*, Your Majesty. I just think it's funny. That's all. You people talk about war and ‘tactics’ when you're missing the point. If you want these—heh—*Demons* gone, just ask me. I told you how they got in, didn't I? I've got tons of good ideas on how to get rid of them, too.”

“Speak, then.”

The Blighted King looks at me. I stand, clear my throat.

“Okay, have you thought about asking them *nicely*?”

He stares. The Blighted Queen raises her mace. I roll my eyes.

“*Fine*. It's nighttime. They're rushing through the corridors, probably right here if the Fool told them where you are.”

“So?”

“So...make it harder? Your hallways are nice and bright. There's too much light! I say...douse the lights. Make it dark.”

The Blighted King looks at Nereshal. The [Mage] hesitates, nods.

“That could slow their progress, confuse them. The palace is labyrinthian.”

I tap my foot on the ground. Wait a second, I forgot my big shoes! I'd better go get them—well, maybe later.

“Now might be nice.”

Nereshal stares at me, and then raises his hand. I see flashing symbols, bright lights as he commands the castle's magic—I edge over to where Isodore is standing, pale-faced.

“Shove over a bit, will you? I never got a chance at the bread basket.”

She stares at me and flees. I munch down on a loaf as Nereshal does something magical. Bloody. And toothy. *That’s* going to hurt coming out.

“The lights have been extinguished. Now. [Heart of Darkness].”

He intones a spell or something and the other mages join in. Darkness spins from his fingertips, flooding out the corridors, turning the hallways pitch black. I grin.

“Lights out.”

Now the Demons are obscured from view. But I’ll just bet they’re having a bad time finding their way. The Blighted King stares at me. I grin.

“Well? Time to get a sword and start chopping.”

“We cannot see the enemy. Should we not barricade ourselves?”

I roll my eyes. He’s really not good at this, is he?

“If you want to wait for the Demon King to show up with an army, *sure*. Otherwise, I’d go corridor by corridor and cut up everything you see with those shiny swords you give out. By the way, where’s mine?”

He ignores that. Skinflint. The Blighted King looks at the projection of his palace in the air. Nereshal’s changed it to a map of the castle. I stare at it. Lots of corridors, rooms...hey, is that my room I see?

“There are servants in the halls. *Guests* of the crown. If we cannot see our enemy, we may cut them down by mistake.”

I look at him, tilting my head to one side and the other.

“So? They’re dead anyways. If you want, send in your pretty little [Knights] and have them die. But then you’ll lose valuable warriors as

opposed to, well, *people*. If I were you, I'd just blast each corridor with magic. One by one."

He stares at me. I grin. The Blighted King looks around and realizes he has an audience. He shakes his head.

"Nereshal. Go. Take six of the eight [Mages] here and every warrior that may be spared. Blast the corridors only as a last resort. My lady—"

"I will go."

The Blighted Queen walks past me, mace in hand. I laugh. And turn.

"Ooh, you're joining in on the fun? In that case, let's have a competition, Queen lady. Who can kill more?"

She glares at me.

"I do not compete with peasants."

"And I don't compete with Queens. But I'll make an exception for *you*."

She doesn't reply. She strides towards a door, and the warriors follow. I sigh. The Blighted King looks at me.

"That may not be enough. The mage attempting to create a portal is the real threat."

"You think? And here I thought you were stupid. Leave the mage to *me*."

I grin at him. The King looks uncertain.

"You think you can defeat two of the Demon King's champions?"

"Eh...it looks like fun?"

I scratch my head and shrug. He stares at me.

"If you are able, we will shower you with wealth and whatever you desire."

“Pancakes?”

Blank look. No one else laughs either. Tough crowd. I turn. The little voice in my head is back. Oh no, what have you done, what are you doing, so on and so forth. I ignore him. Now, I had a good idea. What was it?

I snap my fingers. The Blighted King blinks. Nereshal raises a hand. Touchy. You’d think I nailed him in the balls or something.

“I’ve got it! I’ll take care of your mage. I just need a few things. Time, for one.”

“Whatever you need, within reason we will give it to you.”

“A map, a [Mage] who can cast a few spells for me, and a few shiny knives, Your Majesty. Give me that and I’ll solve your problems for you. Oh, and I want your sword.”

He stares at me. I scratch my head.

“Oh, and some healing potions. I’m going to have to kill some people as well. You said those Demons are all fearless? Sounds like *fun*.”

I grin. And my smile is bloody. Missing tooth. The Blighted King looks at me as if I’m crazy.

Which I completely am.

The Demons run through the palace of the Blighted King in Rhir. They are armed for war, prepared for this day. Enchanted swords in hand, they slaughter anyone they come across. They have a target.

But they cannot find him. The darkness is all-consuming. The lights that had illuminated their way have vanished. Now a magical darkness steals through the castle, so that those without powerful Skills or magic are unable to see. And those who can see—

Are fighting.

Humans, Drakes, Selphids, creatures of every species hold corridors, fighting. Some are [Lords], others [Merchants] or simple [Warriors]. Some aren't even meant to fight. But they hold the line as the Blighted King's orders fill them with strength. Their flesh is like iron, and they do not break.

But their enemies do not fall back. They are Fearless, elite. Chosen. And they push their way further and further into the palace, killing, searching.

A group of sixteen warriors runs down a narrow corridor, weapons at the ready. They are ready for an ambush. They are not ready to hear the sound echoing down the corridor ahead of them.

Humming. A voice in the darkness. The Fearless pause, and their leader holds up a hand. One of them has a shortbow and he fires it ahead. They hear a *thunk*, an impact.

The humming stops. The Demons move ahead, cautiously. Then they see him.

A Human. He's large, heavy, shorter than average. His face is dead white, his nose and mouth red. An arrow sticks out of his shoulder. He's standing in the hallway.

And he's *laughing*.

Giggling, as if the arrow sticking out of his shoulder is funny. The Fearless stare at him for a second. They are without fear. Their leader points, they charge.

“Hi there. My name is Tom!”

Shadows in the night. The [Clown] laughs as he tears the sword away from the first Demon and runs the second through. The warriors stab into his stomach. One nearly cuts his arm off. The [Clown] laughs. He grabs one of the warriors, ignoring the blade in his stomach.

“Hahahahahahaha—gotcha!”

He vanishes along with the warrior he’s holding. The Demons turn. They search for their comrade as one of their number bleeds and dies on the ground. The Human is nowhere to be seen. They continue onwards. They go for ten feet when they hear a voice.

“Hey. Miss me?”

Someone steps out from the shadows behind them. The [Clown] grins. His wounds on his stomach are closed. His arm is intact. He raises two knives and throws them as the Fearless turn. One strikes just above an ear; the other Demon dodges.

“That’s one. Two, if you count the guy I killed. And the girl I grabbed. That was a girl, right?”

The Fearless are without fear. They charge at him, trying to maneuver in the tight corridor. The [Clown] laughs as he cuts into them. Without fear. They cut each other. He grabs another and vanishes. They turn and run.

“Do you want to know how I got these scars? Wait a second—”

He appears down the next corridor, laughing. His wounds are closed. He smiles at the Fearless.

“Have we met before?”

They pause. They stare at him. The Fearless feel no fear. They cannot. Unease, trepidation, terror—all are emotions they have forgotten. But they

still feel. And what they feel is—

Disturbed. The [Clown] strolls towards them. They back up. This time they loose arrows at him. They burn his body with magic. He vanishes, laughing.

He appears again minutes later. The Fearless split up. They feel no fear. But they do not understand. He's laughing. As they cut him, he laughs, as he bleeds, he laughs. And each time they grow fewer in number.

The next time the [Clown] appears, the Fearless retreat. They do not feel fear. But that means they do not understand it either. All they feel is confusion. Uncertainty. They break and run against an enemy they cannot kill. And the [Clown] laughs. He turns.

And vanishes.

I love a good show. So when I appear in the banquet hall, I twirl. The [Mage] who teleported me steps back. I pat his cheek.

“Thanks for the pickup! Beam me up...uh, your name isn't Scotty, is it?”

He's panting too hard to speak. Nereshal walks towards me. He has a gash on a cheek. I saw him freeze a corridor full of Demons. All I had to do was walk up and stab them. He takes all the fun out of life.

“Are the Demons still present in that corridor?”

I shrug.

“They ran.”

“The Fearless?”

“Yeah. False advertising, I call that. Anyways, how are things?”

He ignores me and walks over to a map. The Blighted King is standing over it, plotting the Demons’ advance. Nereshal flicks his fingers, and a corridor clears. One corridor. Most are red, showing Demon-controlled territory, or contested. I lean on the [Mage] who teleported me until he falls down.

“Hey King, what’s up? Are we losing? I bet we are.”

The Blighted King stares at me as I bounce over. Isodore, standing at his side, stares at me. At my stomach.

“You’re bleeding.”

“Am I? I barely noticed. Wait a second, how bad is it?”

I turn, and the people at the table gasp. I look at my back.

“Huh. I could have sworn I had flesh there. Is my spine supposed to look like that?”

“Healing potion!”

There’s already one coming this way. I grab it. The [Healer] babbles something about using it slowly, not straining my body, and so on. I wrestle with her for the bottle.

“Come on, come *on*, I’m wasting time here. Give me that!”

Potion, meet back. Back...so *that’s* what it’s supposed to look like. I giggle and turn back to the Blighted King. And the map.

“Let me see. There’s a clear corridor here, an empty one here...and I just cleared that one.”

I trace a line down the map. The Blighted King stares at me.

“Do you have what is needed to complete this plan you refuse to speak of?”

“Just a minute, needy! I think...yes! Now I just need some things from you, my good pal Nereshal here, and...the Fool.”

I glance sideways. The banquet hall has been transformed. Tables have been upended, places made ready for people too wounded to fight to rest, and guards are standing at all the entrances. But hey, some things never change.

The Fool’s face has definitely changed. I think someone stepped on it. Or kicked it. Repeatedly. Princess Erille is standing in front of him, tears in her eyes, trying to defend him from further abuse. Touching. I grin and walk over to her.

“Stand back.”

Isodore pushes past me. She drags Erille away; the girl kicks at her, fighting, shouting for the Fool. I bend down. The Fool barely looks at me. He’s still under a spell. I think he can’t move.

“Hey buddy. Want to go for a walk?”

“We must know what you intend.”

The Blighted King stares at me as I drag the Fool with me. Nereshal has a wand in his hand. He looks so grim! I shrug.

“I’m going to do the hostage negotiation thing.”

“With the *Fool*?”

The Blighted King looks incredulous.

“Just wait and see! Nereshal thinks it’ll work, don’t you, buddy?”

The mage glares at me, but nods.

“I am aware of what he wants. I believe it may work, Your Majesty. I will teleport myself back in case of trouble. But we are running out of time.”

The King stares at me and his mage. He nods shortly.

“Go, then.”

He stares at the Fool. The Fool glares back. I sigh.

“Get a room, you two.”

They stare at me. I scowl.

“What? It’s hard to be funny. You want to make a better joke? *You* try coming up with it on the spot.”

“What do you call a King who slaughters his own people?”

The Fool mutters, spitting blood. Nereshal hits him. I grin.

“Not bad.”

“This way. Down this corridor, left here...you know, this would be a lot easier if I didn’t have to drag you.”

“I know.”

The Fool and I move down the corridors I’ve cleared, me pushing and carrying him. He seems determined not to move. Not that he can. Paralysis spell or something Nereshal used on him. I laugh.

“I wonder where Nereshal went? I guess he’s busy killing Demons. He’s cool like that.”

“There is nothing noble about it. There is nothing about this war that’s worth admiring.”

The Fool mumbles around swollen lips. I laugh at him. I do that a lot.

“What, you think the Demons are right? Is that why you did all this?”

The Fool is silent. I round a corridor. Now, was it left, or right? Wait a second, *up*. I drag him up the stairs. He speaks as I reach the top.

“The Demons are willing to kill for their survival. I don’t think they’re right. But they aren’t wrong either. They fight to live. While the Blighted King—do you know what he has done? All the horrors he has committed in the name of defeating the Demons?”

“Nope. Want to tell me? I could take notes.”

The Fool glares at me as I drag him by his feet down an empty corridor. You know, for variety.

“Why didn’t you walk away? If you had, I could have gotten Erille to safety, and Isodore! Now they’ll both die, more likely than not. You’re on the wrong side, Tom.”

“Side? *Side*?”

I kick him. The Fool groans through gritted teeth. I pick him up by the feet and glare at his knees.

“You’re an idiot, Fool. The Demons, the Blighted King—they’re just *sides*. There’s no right or wrong! I didn’t choose to help these idiots because I thought they were right. I just thought both sides deserved a funny man helping them. It makes things more entertaining that way.”

He doesn’t respond. I drag on. Okay, now I’m up another flight of stairs. I go up, listening to the Fools’ face smack on every step.

He's barely conscious by the time I get to the top. He mumbles and I have to lean down to listen.

"It could have all ended today. It could have. Why did you have to speak? Why...?"

I blink at him. Shrug.

"Because, Fool, it's in my nature. It's in yours as well. Why do you think people stare at us? We, the two sad idiots who dance around for them. It's because this war is like a performance, Fool."

"I don't understand."

"Of course you don't. So I'll make it simple for you, Fool. Here's why."

I pat him on the head and lean down. I whisper in his ear.

"I want to see what comes *next*."

He looks up at me.

"That's all?"

"Pretty much."

"Damn you."

"So they say. But here I am. And here...we are."

I drag him the rest of the way down the corridor. There's a man waiting for us there. Nereshal's got some cuts down one arm, but he looks pretty good considering he took an alternate route here.

"Hey."

I wave at him. Nereshal stares at me.

"Are you ready?"

“Sort of. Hold on—can I go to the bathroom first? No? Fine, I’ll just go off the edge.”

Nereshal drags the Fool upright. I push him towards the end of the corridor, and then out. Out, through a door, and onto the battlements of a tower. High up. I stare down at the courtyard below. At the Demons standing down there, fighting with people at the gates, protecting the [Mage].

They haven’t spotted me. Oh wait. No, they have. One of them, the [Archer] with the big frickin’ bow, is pointing. The Demons look up. I wave.

“Demons!”

Nereshal’s voice thunders down at them. He stands back, away from the battlements, hands raised as he concentrates on a spell. I edge over, using the Fool as a shield. My voice, made incredibly large by magic, echoes down at them.

“Hi! How are you all doing tonight? Good? May you drink from the blood of a thousand Human skulls and all that. Hey, what’s with all the soldiers these days? It’s like you can’t even assassinate a Blighted King without tripping over them.”

They stare up at me. I grumble.

“No one likes observational humor. Okay, see this guy? This is your friend. The Fool. Wait, what’s your real name?”

I stare at him. The Fool holds still. He’s staring down at the [Mage] specializing in teleportation magic, far below. Now I finally get a good look at her and...

“That’s a lot of tentacles.”

“That’s her hair.”

“What’s with her arms?”

“She was hurt in war.”

“She’s looking right at us. Hey you. Mage lady! Hi! Do you know this guy?”

I point to the Fool, balancing him on the edge of the battlements. The [Mage] does seem to know him. She’s staring up at him. And what a stare. I look at the Fool. He’s doing the same kind of stare back at her. Another piece of the puzzle snaps into place.

“Hey, *wait* a second...you like her! And she likes you! You said you were talking to your true love back in the courtyard—fancy that!”

I slap my hand to my forehead and nearly drop the Fool. Nereshal hisses at me and I grab him just in time before he goes over the edge and falls a few hundred feet below.

“Whoops. Sorry. Now, that makes me feel *awful* about what’s going to happen next.”

“Kill me. She won’t betray her mission for me.”

The Fool looks calmly at me. I shake my head.

“Don’t be so negative. I believe in true love. And you see—”

I call down at them. The Demon [Archer] is aiming at us, but the Fool’s in the way. I laugh down at them.

“Give up! Surrender or the Fool gets it!”

“You’re an idiot. Do you really think that they would all give up their lives for a single Human? For me?”

That really hurts, coming from the Fool himself. I glare at him.

“No? Maybe I should throw you off. Well? See, she doesn’t like that, does she?”

The [Mage] is pointing at me, arguing with the [Archer]. He’s aiming at us. I see her raising her mangled arms to strike at him, shoulders tensing up, and then sagging. She turns away, and then looks at the Fool. The Demon [Archer] nocks an arrow.

“Uh oh. I think she’s giving up on you. Don’t do it! Stop! *In the naaaaaaaaaaaaame of love!*”

The Fool ignores me. So do the Demons below. The [Archer] looks like he’s lining up for a good shot. I scowl at him. He’s whispering to her.

“Goodbye.”

“You suck. I came here for true love, and what do I get? Sacrifice. Heartbreak! Who ever heard of a love story like that?”

The Fool doesn’t answer. He closes his eyes, waiting. I turn to Nereshal. The [Mage]’s brow is creased in concentration. He nods at me. I scowl at him.

“You suck. I just wanted to say that to you. You suck, and your kingdom sucks, and you—”

I turn to the Fool.

“—Suck. And all you Demons suck. You hear me? I’m done with you all! Let’s end it now! Goodbye, cruel world! This is *it!*”

I see the Demon pulling back the arrow, ready to loose. I grab the Fool. He looks into my eyes, unafraid to die. I grin, push him—

And jump.

This is what they see. The Demons, looking high overhead. The Blighted King, watching from the banquet hall. The people of Rhir, staring up at the palace below. They see a body falling from the tower, a laughing man. A fool.

But not the Fool. A [Clown] falls through the air, laughing, his voice echoing. He laughs and laughs as the ground rises to meet him, laughs at the disbelief on the Demons' faces, laughs at the cry of surprise from the Fool.

And high above him in the tower, the great mage Nereshal casts his spell. As the ground rushes up to reach Tom, he *blurs*. He doesn't stop falling, but a shield of magic appears around him, a bubble of energy. And he teleports.

Not far. Not to the ground, or vast distances like the [Mage] below him is attempting to do. Nereshal's spell is simple. It teleports Tom a few hundred feet forwards and to the right. He falls and lands on top of the Demon with the bow.

"*Oof*. Hey, that actually hurt. I almost...oh, hi there buddy."

The [Clown] bounds to his feet. The Demon beneath him twitches. His body is broken. Tom stabs him in the head and he stops moving. He turns to the escort of Demons surrounding the [Mage]. And grins.

"Hey there. Want to play catch?"

One runs at him. Tom throws something. A sword. It *hums* through the air and slashes through the Demon, and the one behind him. The other Demons move, and a second sword slices into one's chest, cutting through

magical armor like paper. Tom flicks his hand, and a sword shining with bright light appears.

“They call this one Blightbane. Or something. I borrowed it from the Blighted King. And now you get it! Catch!”

He throws it. The sword whirls through the air, cuts through a Demon’s head and another’s arm without slowing. Tom pulls another artifact out of the air. Grins.

“It’s all in the wrist. Who wants a scimitar? You? Here!”

The Demons fall. The elite guard drop, and the [Mage] backs up. She raises her staff, points at Tom, cries out. One of his knives sticks from her shoulder, another in her arm. Tom kicks her before she can move.

“Ah, ah. I don’t want to learn how to fly today. Turns out I’m no good at it. Now, what shall we do with you?”

He grins at her. The [Mage] gasps. Tom raises a hand.

“Wanna see a magic trick?”

He reaches for her face, ignoring the scream from above. He touches her face, reaches behind her ear and pulls out...a gold coin. She stares at it.

“See? You should always wash! Now, let me see. Do I have a hat? No I do not. And a bunny? No I do not. But I can pull a knife out! How about a slightly rotten apple? No?”

She stares at him and utters a word. It sounds like despair. Her body vanishes underneath Tom and he sits down.

“No one’s a fan of my tricks. Oh well.”

He gets up, brushes himself off, and looks around. The Demons remaining in the courtyard stare at him. Tom looks up, and grins as

Nereshal floats down. The [Chronomancer]'s eyes burn like fire, and magic crackles from his fingertips in the form of lightning.

“Well, it looks like I have an assistant for today. Ladies and gentlemen, Demons all.”

He bows as the soldiers of the Demon King ready their weapons, hearing their comrades falling from the palace. They rush towards him, and Tom straightens. A sword appears in his hand, a dagger in the other. He laughs.

“Let’s begin the *show*.”

This is how it ends. Boring. I sit on a Demon’s body and hum. Nereshal turns and stares at me. I raise my hands.

“If you don’t like the song, you pick a better one.”

“Do you enjoy acting insane, or is this madness genuine?”

I pause, stare at him. The [Mage] is pretty undamaged for a guy who just killed a few hundred Demons. I shrug.

“Wouldn’t you like to know?”

He grunts and turns away. I get up as I see people streaming out of the palace.

“Hey! I think I win!”

The Blighted Queen ignores me as she walks out into the courtyard, her beloved Blighted King by her side. Her mace is drenched with gore, and the

soldiers around her look wounded and bloody. I see Richard helping Emily out.

“Aw. No one important died.”

“*Hundreds* lie dead within the castle and thousands more in the city!”

Nereshal snaps at me. I raise my hands.

“Yeah, but no one *important* died. Let’s be honest.”

He turns away from me. I whistle a tune as the Blighted King approaches. He stares at me.

“You let her go.”

“Correction: she didn’t like my magic tricks.”

I’m offended, really I am. The Blighted King stares at me, and looks at the crushed Demon archer guy I landed on. He looks satisfied as he stands over his corpse.

“One more of the Demon King’s limbs taken away. It will suffice.”

“We will claim vengeance for this.”

The Blighted Queen’s eyes blaze with battle fury. Nereshal nods. I yawn.

“Maybe. Or maybe we all let bygones be bygones?”

They stare at me. I raise my hands.

“Fine. Fine. I guess we do it your way.”

“We must begin to reconstruct. Find the wounded—and whatever Demon soldiers remain in hiding. It will not be safe in the palace, Your Majesty. I recommend caution and staying under guard until—”

Nereshal is speaking to the Blighted King as the people stream into the courtyard, and the King is staring around when it happens. I hear the scream. Erille's voice. She's pointing. I look up.

"Huh. I didn't see that coming."

A body falls from the tower. The same tower Nereshal and I fell from. This time, it's the Fool. He tumbles through the air, only there's no magic to slow his fall or break it. He lands on the ground, headfirst.

Thump. The impact makes people run back. I see the Fool's neck twist, and then his body *spring* upwards. He tumbles forwards, mows down two of the people closest to him, and then comes to a stop, legs comically dangling in the air. I blink as the Fool flips onto his feet. He looks unsteady, but grim. And he's no longer held by magic.

I begin applauding.

"That was probably the best pratfall I've ever seen in my life. Bravo! Do it again!"

"*Fool!*"

The Blighted King snarls. He points, and Nereshal moves, quick as lightning.

"[Hold—]"

He never gets to finish the spell. The Fool flips backwards into the air, doing a double backflip and throws something. A ball bounces off Nereshal's face and he staggers. I hear a *crack* and see his nose bend out of shape.

"Hail to the Blighted King, the murderer of innocents! Your Majesty, you and I have unfinished business. I am the world's greatest [Fool], and a fool deserving of the title! And today I seek your life, my King. For your

sins. And mine, for letting you continue. No more. I will put an end to it today.”

The Fool’s voice booms throughout the courtyard. He lands on his feet and points at the King. I sit back.

“Oh man, this is going to be so good.”

The Blighted King looks down at the Fool. His eyes are cold, distant. He turns his head.

“Kill the traitor.”

The soldiers rush at the Fool. And the Fool—fights. He cartwheels into the first man, sending the man in armor tumbling comically to the ground. He spins, and two blades appear in his hands. He slashes a [Knight] in armor across his helmetless face, bumps Emily over with his hip, and tosses the second dagger through the heart of a [Mage] fifty feet away.

“Ooh, he’s good.”

The Fool spins into the air, flicking daggers at people rushing at him. He rolls under Richard’s sword and trips him up. The [Knight] goes down and the Fool kicks Richard in the head. He bounces about, too fast to be caught.

The Blighted Queen rushes at him. The Fool dances away from her, tossing daggers. She blocks each one with her mace. He throws something. She trips.

A juggling ball. The Blighted Queen is on her feet in a moment, but too late. The Fool races towards the Blighted King. A fireball flies towards him from the left, too fast to dodge—

He turns, grabs for the fire. It disappears. He makes it vanish. I sit up.

“Whoa. Can *I* do that?”

I should take notes! Then I see an angry [Mage] standing in front of the Blighted King. Nereshal's nose is bloody, but his hands crackle with magic. I carefully lean back.

“[Lightning Storm].”

Bolts of lightning blast from his fingertips, the same ones that emptied the courtyard of life minutes ago. The Fool stands in the center of the electrical storm.

Time slows as the lightning begins to strike the Fool. I see him twist. His hands rise. One bolt of lightning is stretching towards his chest. His hand blocks the bolt, and then the lightning collects in it. The Fool spins, tosses it, and then catches another bolt. He throws it back at Nereshal.

He juggles the lightning.

Explosions. I feel one blast me off my feet. I roll, and see the lightning storm *reverse* course. Countless bolts strike Nereshal. I see him throw up his hands, and then it's over. In the blink of an eye. Nereshal collapses, a shield of magic disintegrating around him as his eyes roll up in his head.

The Fool stands in front of him, breathing heavily. His hands are blackened, the skin smoking. But he still moves. He races towards the Blighted King and before anyone can stop him, has a knife to his throat.

“Now we come to it, Your Majesty! Now we put an end to this pathetic performance. I should have done this years ago!”

He shouts. The courtyard is still. There are a hundred bows trained on the Fool, [Mages] ready with spells, warriors with blades. None of them dare move. Because the knife at the Blighted King's throat is faster than them all.

The Blighted King stands still. His voice is calm.

“Do it, then, traitor. But tell us why, first. You pledged your loyalty to us, to this nation. Why betray it?”

“Why? *Why?*”

The Fool is trembling. His hands still smoke. There are tears in his voice, but none in his eyes. I can see Erille, standing with her hands on her mouth next to Isodore. The Fool can’t look at her. A tableau.

“Why do you think? All you’ve done, all the horrors you’ve committed, the crimes—I could understand. That, for war. But the ritual? The *cost*? Never.”

“What I do, I do for my people. So that they may live.”

The Fool shakes his head. His dagger presses into the King’s throat, drawing blood. I hear a sound from the Blighted Queen. Pain.

“You do not deserve to be a King. Tell them what you did. *Tell them!*”

“No. Kill me. I will die first.”

The Fool hesitates. The Blighted King is ready to impale himself on the dagger before either one speaks. I can see him looking, staring at Erille, hand tensing on the hilt—

“My turn.”

Everyone turns as I stand, brushing myself off. The Fool looks at me. I’m not sure if he hates me, even now.

“There’s nothing you can do, Tom. Step away. The Blighted King dies, and I die too. Let that be an end to it.”

“Oh, come on. It’s not over. You’re here, Fool, and so am I. We can’t let it end with you dying just like that. We need a final grudge match, a proper end. [Fool] vs [Clown]. A battle for the ages. What do you say?”

He stares at me. I grin at him. He looks away.

“You truly are mad, aren’t you? You...I’m sorry. Sorry you ever came here, Tom.”

“Don’t say that. Tell you what; I’ll make you an offer you can’t refuse.”

There are two knives in my hand. I have three left. The Fool stares at me.

“You can’t scare me with death. I’m ready for it.”

I roll my eyes.

“Not your death, obviously. I’m thinking more poetically.”

I look past the Blighted King, past the Fool. At a girl staring with wide eyes. The Fool’s mouth opens. He screams.

“No!”

The knife flies past the Blighted King, through the air, towards Erille. Too fast for anyone to block. Anyone, but a Fool.

He lets the Blighted King go and dives for the knife. I’ve never seen a man move that fast. The Fool catches the blade in midair, right in front of Erille’s face. Of course, I knew he’d do that.

That’s why I threw three.

The Fool’s hands blur as he throws all three knives. Two fly towards the Blighted King, striking him in the chest and in the shoulder. The next one strikes me in the stomach. It doesn’t slow me down as I tackle the [Fool]. We roll around on the ground, hands flashing, fighting for daggers, pulling them out of the air, out of each other’s trick spaces.

“You idiot! You mad monster!”

He screams at me as he slashes my face, my arms and front. I laugh, stabbing back. He dodges, even locked together as we are. He kicks me away and we stand. I throw a dagger, his dagger, and he throws it right back. I snatch it out of the air and we cut at each other, dodging, weaving, too close for anyone to interfere.

“Why do you do it? Why!?”

He’s shouting, stumbling. His hands don’t grasp the knives properly. I laugh.

“Do you want to know why? Do you know what separates the two of us? Clown and fool? It’s easy!”

I grab his arm. He stabs me, but I don’t let go. I draw him closer as he stabs, looking for my heart.

“You’re a fool. People laugh at you. You make them laugh. But I? I’m a clown. I laugh at the world.”

He stares at me. My free hand reaches out. I grin.

“And guess what I just found?”

His eyes widen. I pull the fireball *out* of the air, out of the space he kept it in. He tries to back away—

And there’s fire.

The Fool’s body lies on the ground, blackened. One of his eyelids is burnt away, exposing an eye. His right hand—gone. The rest of his body is destroyed.

But he is still alive. I walk towards him and pick him up in my arms. I don't feel my body anymore.

"That's funny. Are you...crying, Tom?"

He looks at me. I stare down at him. Me. The laughing man in my head is gone.

"I guess I am, Fool. I'm sorry. It was me. I did all this."

"You don't say?"

We stand alone in a blackened crater in the courtyard. Alone, but for all the witnesses. The Blighted King lies on the ground, breathing heavily. But he is alive. And the rest, the citizens of Rhir who pour through the gates, the battered Drake company led by Cirille, gather. To see a dying Fool, and the clown who killed him. One, a beloved face turned traitor. The other a monster. A hero.

"I'm so sorry, Fool. I don't know what I would have done. But—I couldn't let you. I knew that."

"I suppose not. You're not a funny fellow, Tom. Not funny. But you don't want to be, I think. But do you know what's funny?"

His voice is hoarse. A whisper. No one else can hear him. I have to put my ear to his lips.

"What? What is it?"

"The Blighted King. Why do you think I turned on him? It was the day after the ritual that I knew. When you were summoned, I learned the cost."

"What cost?"

"Crimson."

"What?"

“They wear it. Crimson for the lost. Miscarriages, they said. A curse. But it wasn’t. And the price was—high.”

I raise my head. Standing in a group across from me are the ladies of the Blighted King’s court. Lady Zekyria stares at me, her face pale. Her gown is torn and scorched. But light red, closer to pink, and white.

For her dead child.

“Yes.”

The Fool’s whisper is pitiful. He looks up at me, pain in his eyes.

“Ten thousand unborn souls. For you sixty. Isn’t that—that—”

His remaining eyelid flickers. His other eye strays before snapping back on me. He’s dying.

“A funny joke, Tom. A terrible joke.”

“But it’s over, Fool. It’s over and done.”

“No.”

The Fool reaches up. His hand—flakes away at the touch. But he looks me in the eye.

“A hundred thousand. He wants an army this time. An army. He’d sacrifice so many for any edge. And if a hundred thousand doesn’t work, he’ll sacrifice a million. Every unborn child, to kill Demons. To kill people just like you and me.”

I stare at him. Of course. I can’t be surprised. It makes sense, in the horrible way of this world. I’m almost...numb? But the Fool cares. He cares so much, and the pain in his eyes—he whispers his last words to me.

“I cannot stop him. I couldn’t end it. Or save her. But you can. Protect her. Take her away.”

I look up and see Erille. She stares at me. Me, the man who killed her beloved Fool. He grasps my arm.

“Please. I wished—”

I wait for the rest. It never comes. The Fool’s hand grips my arm, tight, stiff. He doesn’t let go. Even in death.

The foolish clown sits in the broken courtyard as the people gather on the balconies, flood through the gates. Royals, knights and mages and dignitaries, common folk and people from another world. He weeps, holding the body of the Fool in his hands.

No one else sheds a tear. No one. They wipe them away, hiding them, like shame. The [Princess] has to hide them. But the clown wears his tears on his face. And then, his sobs turn into laughter.

He laughs at them, at him, at this broken world. And he holds the broken Fool to his body, the hero who tried to put an end to a bad joke.

It should be raining. But the night is cool and still. Yet there is liquid of a kind. Blood flows through the courtyard, pooling. It reflects poorly, but someone watches in that crimson mirror. The devil himself laughs and bows to the audience only he can see. His voice can only be heard by the clown.

“Next time, dear Tom. Next time. They’ll be coming, the lost and afraid. From our world.”

He points, mockingly, to the Blighted King, whose eyes are on the clown, the [Hero] of the day. He laughs, as the clown levels up. As a [Clown] and [Hero] both.

“You can’t escape it. Not this. And now, more will come. More, to dance and laugh along with this joke. Can you stop it? You can’t. But I can. And I’ll be with you, each step of the way. Whenever you call—and when you don’t.”

He bows and fades. But his voice remains, echoing, reminding the clown of all he lost. And promising him, telling him of the future.

“I’ll be waiting.”

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It was said that of the five continents, Terandria was the wealthiest, the safest, and the most advanced place to live in the entire world. And that was true. But only if you averaged things out.

Wealthiest? Terandria might be second place to Baleros, where the riches of the jungle waited and the companies turned blood into gold, or third if you debated the relative size of Izril and compared the three populations of Gnoll, Drake, and Humans to the smaller Terandrian continent. However, it was certainly a rich place, and fewer people died for its wealth.

As for advanced—in magic and technology, Terandria boasted the sole gathering of Dwarf-kind, and thus exported steel and metals far stronger than most. And its strong ties to Wistram meant that mages frequented its shores. However...one could say the same of Baleros and Rhir, whose militaries boasted the most ancient artifacts and highest-level craftspeople.

But safest. Yes, Terandria could call itself safe. Wars were endemic to this world and Terandria had its fair share. But in Terandria, there were *rules*. Wars were begun and ended with signed declarations, while laws against slaughtering civilians and non-combatants were enforced by all nations. And since the populations of each nation were largely Human, they seldom wiped each other out.

It was a subject of mockery in other countries across the world. Terandrians were cowards, it was said. The fat, bickering rulers of each nation would roll over when poked with an ink-stained quill. And perhaps it was true that Terandria had grown too political, that it fought with words

and poisoned drinks more than actual soldiers and armies. Perhaps they had grown soft.

But Lyonette missed her home, all the same. Sometimes. She remembered why she hated it, but she also remembered that she had never seen a dead body before leaving. Not once. She was too delicate as a [Princess] to look upon a poisoned uncle's face, or go to the funeral of an esteemed [Knight]. And death didn't intrude in her old life. Terandria was safe. Genteel.

On Izril, even Gold-rank adventurers could die. Good, innocent Gnolls could die. Brunkr, someone Lyonette had feared, someone she'd barely known, but begun to like—could die without any reason. And his killer would get away.

People died on Izril. And when they did, they tore holes out of Lyonette's heart.

Morning. Lyonette woke up and felt like the sky had fallen. She stared up at the ceiling of her room dully, too tired to get up and start her usual routine. What was the point?

She only moved when she noticed two things. First, that Ryoka was gone. Yes, she remembered. But it was still another empty space where it should have been filled.

The second thing was that Mrsha was missing. *That* made Lyonette sit up. She dressed herself quickly and hurried downstairs. She found Mrsha in the common room, to her intense relief.

The little Gnoll was lying on the ground in a corner, by the patched-up wall. She was a little ball of white fur, lolling on the ground. Listlessly. Mrsha stared blankly at a wall.

“Mrsha?”

The Gnoll’s short tail wasn’t wagging like usual. She didn’t respond when Lyonette came over. Lyonette tried to gather her up into her arms, but a sense in her head stopped her. She paused as a huge bee crawled onto Mrsha’s head and fanned its wings gently.

“Apista, shoo.”

Lyonette gently made the bee get off Mrsha by offering it her arm. The bee obligingly crawled onto Lyonette’s head; it wasn’t pleasant, feeling its sharp little legs crawling on her skin, but Lyonette put up with it. She bent and tried to pick up Mrsha.

“Come on Mrsha, don’t lie there.”

The Gnoll resisted. Passively. She was limp as a rag and *heavy*. Lyonette stopped trying to pick her up and tried a different tack.

“I know you’re sad, Mrsha. I am too. But...I bet you’re hungry. You should eat.”

Mrsha didn’t respond. Lyonette crooned to her, edging over and stroking the back of Mrsha’s head.

“I know you like honey. Why don’t you have some with eggs? And Erin made a pizza two days ago. And she made lasagna last week. What if you had a bit of all that? With some sweet juice? Milk?”

The Gnoll cub’s tail twitched. It began to wag ever so slightly. Lyonette kept encouraging her. In the end, Mrsha got up and padded over to a table. She sat there, staring at the wood, while Lyonette hurried into the kitchen.

Apista flew onto the table and twitched her antennae to keep Mrsha company.

Breakfast was a thin slice of lasagna, half a slice of pizza, a fried egg drizzled with a spot of honey, and hot milk. The last of the milk, in fact. It was used often. Mrsha ate her breakfast slowly, but with a sense of growing...peace? Calm? Perhaps the word was relief. A temporary relief from sorrow. Yes, that was it.

Tending to Mrsha helped Lyonette as well. She was able to eat a bit herself—just a slice of the odd ‘pizza’ that Erin was so fond of making. It certainly was easy to eat. And so she was present when Drassi walked in.

“Lyonette, I’m so *sorry*.”

That was the first thing the female Drake said. She’d heard, of course. Not all of it, but enough. And she’d gotten all the big parts. Regrika Blackpaw, the traitor. Her murder of Brunkr and then the death of a Gold-rank adventurer. In Erin’s inn. And all this right before the Goblin Lord’s army marched by the city.

“It was terrifying. All of the Watch was on the walls and we were ordered to stay indoors, but we were all out on the streets, of course. I kept thinking, ‘what about Erin and all the people in The Wandering Inn’? But then I heard you’d all fled to Celum, so I was relieved. But oh, it’s too cruel. And after Brunkr was—”

Lyonette put a hand over Drassi’s mouth and the Drake shut up. Both [Barmaids] looked at Mrsha, who’d paused in eating her egg. Gnoll hearing. Drassi coughed guiltily.

“I want to help. You should stay with Mrsha, you really should. Ishkr’s...not feeling well. I don’t think he’ll be in. But I’m sure I can handle whatever’s needed myself!”

“That’s fine. Thank you. I don’t think we’ll have many guests. Can you help me get ready? We have...the Horns of Hammerad and Halfseekers are still here. And Zel. And Erin. I bet she’ll be down soon.”

Drassi paused. She glanced towards the door and then at Lyonette.

“Erin? I saw her outside just a minute ago.”

“What?”

“Yeah, she was pulling arrows out of the dirt. The ones the Goblins shot. And she had a hammer.”

“A—”

Something went *crack* by one of the windows. Everyone jumped. Lyonette turned, and saw one of the glass windows, open to let the sunlight in. Someone was hitting it. With...a *hammer*?

“Erin!”

When Lyonette raced outside she found Erin, a carpenter’s claw hammer in hand, smashing it repeatedly on the glass window. Erin stopped and turned to Lyonette.

“Morning, Lyonette.”

“Uh—good morning. What are you doing?”

Erin stared at Lyonette. She didn’t look like she’d gotten much sleep. Her eyes were bloodshot and she was unsteady on her feet. She raised the hammer.

“Hitting my windows. With this.”

“Yes. Why?”

“Stress test.”

Erin grunted, and then turned her hammer. She swung the claw end at the window. *Hard*. Lyonette braced herself, but rather than break, the hammer's edge skated across the glass. Erin eyed the undamaged window, and then punched it.

“Ow. That’s tough.”

“What’s all this about?”

“I’m seeing how tough my inn is now. I didn’t tell you—the other day I got [Reinforced Structure].”

“Oh. *Oh!* So that’s why the inn wasn’t damaged when the Goblin Lord —”

“Yeah. But I want to know exactly how strong my inn is.”

Erin studied the window again, and then balled a fist. She took a breath.

“*[Minotaur Punch]!*”

The impact this time was loud and sharp. Lyonette saw Erin pull back her hand, wincing.

“Are you—”

Erin showed her hand to Lyonette. There was no blood. But there was a definite fracture in the glass where she’d hit. It was small, but it was there.

“Not that strong, then.”

She shook her head. Lyonette stared at her. She stared at the window.

“It looks strong to me. You couldn’t break it, and the glass is pretty thin!”

“Yeah. But if I can fracture it, anyone with more than twenty levels in a combat class can probably break it. And someone like Regrika could

probably still put a hole in my walls.”

Regrika. Lyonette felt a cold surge of fear and anger in her stomach when she heard the name. She looked at Erin.

“Do you think she’s going to come back...?”

“No.”

Erin shook her head. She looked at her window, and then turned away. She trudged around to the front of the inn.

“I don’t. But even if I never see her again, what about next time?”

“What do you mean, next time?”

“A Rock Crab. The Goblin Lord’s army. Or another adventurer. Another Skinner. Or...”

Erin shook her head. She looked so tired. Lyonette stared at a boarded-up wall in Erin’s inn, where Moore had smashed through to run from Regrika. That had been before Erin’s new Skill. Now, she wondered if the half-Giant would have been able to manage the feat.

The [Innkeeper] was clearly thinking the same thing.

“Next time, I won’t be able to rely on luck. And that was what it was. Luck saved everyone but Ulrien. Revi still got cut up, Moore needed healing, and Jelaqua...I can’t keep doing what I’ve been doing. I thought I was prepared. I was wrong.”

Lyonette shook her head adamantly.

“You did everything you could! You got *two* Gold-rank teams and Zel Shivertail and a Wall Lord to help you. You made sure Mrsha and I—and Apista—were safely out of the inn. What else could you have done?”

“Something. Anything. When she was fighting, Regrika—I couldn’t scratch her. I bought healing potions, magical items from Octavia—do you know I didn’t think to use any of them? It wouldn’t have mattered if I had, anyways. I need something more. More protection. More power. More...”

She shook her head. Erin glanced towards the open door to her inn, leaking warm air. She went to close it and paused.

“Are you okay? Is Mrsha?”

“I’ll be—”

Lyonette’s throat closed up before she could say she was fine. She wasn’t. Erin looked at her. She had a haunted look in her eyes. And Lyonette remembered that Erin had seen people die before as well.

“Take the day off if you need to. Keep Mrsha company.”

“It’s okay. I can manage. But are you alright? You look...”

“I’m fine. I’ve been through this before.”

“Oh?”

Erin nodded. She stared into her inn, and then turned away. There was something quiet about her today. Quiet, and intense. She wasn’t smiling. She wasn’t frowning or visibly upset, either. She was just...present.

“It doesn’t get better. But I can work without crying this time. Because I have to. It’s easier to have something to do. And so much has happened. Ryoka’s gone. Ivolethe’s gone. Brunkr and Ulrien...the Goblin Lord. I need to...”

She stared up at the blue sky without finishing her sentence. Lyonette looked around. The snow was still thick everywhere she looked. But it was wet. Melting. It would take a week at least for the warming weather to melt the snow. When it did...Lyonette foresaw a lot of mud and water.

“Come on. I’ve got food and Drassi is here. You should have breakfast if you haven’t already. And I’d bet the others will wake up any time now.”

Erin blinked. She looked at Lyonette.

“Yeah. Let’s do that.”

Quietus. That was what followed death. In the moments between grief and anger, reconciliation, regret, denial, and perhaps, peace, there was silence. It was not always the same.

Some wept. Some mourned out loud. Others retreated inwards or found places to go to be alone. Some just...left.

It was the same across the world. In Rhir, a [Clown] sat in a room full of broken mirrors, too full of grief and horror to shed any more tears. A [Princess] wept alone in her bedroom, because she could not show her sadness outside. A kingdom was full of drums, and the people swore vengeance over pyres. Hatred stemmed from grief.

Silence in that place was loud. It was men and women crying out for vengeance, a [King] sitting on his throne, loudly praising those who fought and denouncing traitors. It was the sound of drums, beating to a mourning city. But in the fractured moments of time between each thump of a drum was that moment of silence. Of numb loss.

In a small inn outside of Liscor, the silence was different. It was pure quiet. Hushed voices. A talkative Drake who chattered quietly, trying to make a Gnoll smile. It was adventurers walking downstairs.

The Horns of Hammerad barely spoke. And they left early. Their silence was another contract; hunting down a large nest of Shield Spiders that had

infested a section of Liscor's sewers, burrowing through stone and dirt. Or maybe their eggs had been carried into the tunnels somehow? Either way, it was a job for a Silver-rank team, not Bronze. It was dirty, but it was work to keep them occupied.

They left, but carried the silence with them. Silence was Pisces slipping Mrsha a piece of oily bacon, Ksmvr talking about the mission by himself since no one would join in. Yvlon thanking Lyonette and the two staring at each other for a moment before turning away. Ceria putting a hand on Erin's shoulder.

The Halfseekers were different. Jelaqua was loud, drinking early in the day. Moore and Seborn were naturally quiet, but they filled the air today with sound.

"Now it's just one Gold-rank team in here. At least until the Horns get certified. That means we'd better act the part. Moore, cause some trouble."

"How?"

"Knock over a chair or something. Start a fight."

The half-Giant obligingly turned over a chair. Seborn knocked over his empty cup. Jelaqua looked disgusted. Lyonette giggled a bit, and Mrsha's tail wagged a bit more.

"You two are disgusting, you know that? Looks like I have to cause all the trouble myself. Hey Erin, got anything I can smash?"

"How about a window?"

"What?"

When they heard about Erin's tests on her inn, the Halfseekers all went outside to test the durability of it. They argued, kept themselves busy. Jelaqua rapped on the window, first hard, and then punched it.

“Right. Looks like I *could* break this with my flail, but it might take two swings. Maybe three, depending on how much space I had. Moore could probably put his fist through it as well, but I’d hate to imagine what that’d do to his hand. Seborn...it would be pretty hard.”

Moore sighed.

“I would probably put an enchantment over my hand, Jelaqua. Cover it with vines. Or thorns. I’m not a savage.”

“Good point. Seborn, you think you could break it?”

The Drowned Man shrugged.

“I don’t feel the need. I’d rather just unlatch the window and jump in, or find another route. But I could probably break it with my daggers. It would slow me down, though.”

“Go ahead. I don’t mind.”

Erin stepped back from the window and invited Seborn to use his daggers on it. The Halfseekers eyed her. Jelaqua paused and shook her head.

“Nah. Glass is expensive. It’s good you got the Skill, though. A bit more protection’s always good.”

“You should look into some spells. I know a decent [Enchanter] who does warding spells.”

Moore nodded to Erin. She looked at him.

“Really? How much do they cost? And how strong are they? Would they stop someone like Regrika?”

The Gold-rank adventurers looked at each other. Jelaqua sighed. She scratched at the black stitches around her forehead.

“No. Never mind.”

Erin looked at the stitches. They were holding together the top of Jelaqua’s head, the bit Regrika had sliced off with the rest of her body, but the severed bit was already looking slightly...decomposed.

“Are you okay? Is your body...”

She didn’t know how to complete that sentence. The Selphid grinned at her wearily.

“Damaged. Thanks for asking. I tore a lot of muscles and the top of my head’s rotting off. But hey, *I’m* alive, so who cares about my body?”

She grinned. Erin remembered that Jelaqua’s head had been empty when she’d seen inside. The memory made her want to bring up the lasagna she’d had for breakfast.

“Right. No brains. That’s...a bit icky, if you don’t mind me saying so.”

“Not a problem. Nothing looks pretty from the inside. I should know!”

“But how’d your brains—I mean, your body’s brains—how did they uh, disappear? Is that something you have to do when you—”

Terminology was becoming an issue. Jelaqua smiled.

“Brains have nothing to do with how I control a body. I don’t need ‘em. As for how they disappeared, well...it’s this thing, okay? Excess body fat, useless organs—I get snacky, and sometimes—”

Moore elbowed Jelaqua gently.

“That’s disturbing. Even for me, Jelaqua.”

“Sorry, sorry! You did ask. I know you fleshies don’t like talking about it. But Erin did ask, and I want to be open about that.”

The Selphid raised her hands. Erin smiled at her and resolved never to ask about that again. Or at least not after she'd just eaten. She took a second to compose herself, and then gestured at Jelaqua's head.

"So you need a new body, is that right?"

"Preferably. But I can manage without one if I have to for a month or two. Might get ugly, but I don't know if I'll find a new body around here."

The Selphid grew serious. She nodded towards Liscor.

"Drakes do *not* like people using their bodies. Neither do Gnolls. They have a thing about it. You know, from the Necromancer? And people don't like Selphids in general. It's almost worse than back home because they don't know about Selphids, so there are all these rumors I have to deal with...I'm willing to pay in gold, of course, but I think I'll have to ask around in Celum and that's a gamble."

Erin nodded. The logistics of corpse acquisitions were unfortunately not a new subject to her. Pisces had made similar complaints in the past.

"And I bet you want a good body, right? One with lots of teeth...freshly dead, and probably with muscles, right?"

"She gets it!"

The Selphid turned to Seborn and Moore, looking relieved. They nodded approvingly. Jelaqua walked back inside with the others and sat at a table. Zel was having breakfast. He nodded to Erin, and then winced as Jelaqua began grousing about finding a new host body.

"You would not *believe* how hard it is. Forget having a specific taste in bodies, finding one that's not old, infected with some disease, and in one piece is hard enough. I'm not one of those elitist types, of course—I'll go for anything without a pulse if it can get the job done. Heck, with all the wear and tear in my profession, that's mandatory. But I'd like another

female body. I mean, the male ones are alright, but let's be honest—the dangling bits tend to get eaten by bugs before I can enter the corpse, and that's a pain whenever I have to relieve myself from then on..."

Erin was in a position to regret ever asking about Jelaqua's woes, but at least it was distracting to hear the Selphid grouse. And that was good. True, Zel lost his appetite and Lyonette had to cover Mrsha's ears, but it was fun. In a way.

"What about Antinium bodies?"

"Excuse me?"

Jelaqua paused in her rant about having sex, and stared at Erin. The girl shrugged.

"I know a lot of Antinium die. It's not...good, but if they were willing to give you a body, would you be able to use it?"

Bird paused as he walked downstairs. He had his bow in hand. He nodded.

"Antinium bodies are exceedingly durable."

Erin jumped. She'd forgotten that Bird was staying here! She was about to apologize when she realized that Bird was agreeing with her. The Antinium sat at a table. He was uninjured, and he requested 'unborn birds' for breakfast. As usual. Lyonette gave him a plate of eggs which he began to eat happily.

"Ants? I'd never given it a thought."

Jelaqua looked troubled as she picked at the stitches on her head. Seborn grabbed her hand. She gave him an annoyed look.

"It *itches*."

“It’ll itch more if it fully decomposes.”

“You suck. Okay. Antinium...it’s a thought, Erin, but there’s a few issues. Antinium aren’t welcome in most places on the continent. Also, I’m not familiar with their bodies. It would take a while to get up to speed, and that’s not good if we’re going to take on the dungeon again. I don’t know if their insides are different, which might be dangerous. And I mean, four arms? That’s tricky.”

She waved her two arms around and Erin nodded.

“It’s just a thought. If your uh, head gets rotty, I can ask Klbkch about it.”

“Thanks. Yeah, better that than decomposition, right? I mean, I can deal with maggots and flies laying eggs—just a snack when you get down to it. But people complain of the smell, and then I start *leaking*...”

“Right. Thank you for breakfast. I’ve got to be on my way.”

Zel pushed his plate back. The [General] stood, looking queasy, and Erin saw Jelaqua raise a hand guiltily. Moore covered his face.

“Sorry about that.”

Erin hurried over and cleared the table. Drassi was in the kitchen doing dishes. Zel shook his head.

“Not a problem. I’m in a hurry anyways.”

“Oh? What are you doing?”

The Drake grimaced.

“Sitting with Liscor’s Council, talking, reassuring people, and communicating—slowly—with other cities, mainly. We’re in touch with

Esthelm via [Message] spell and talking over forming another army with the Walled Cities.”

“Esthelm?”

That was right. Esthelm was right in the Goblin Lord’s path if he was heading north. Erin felt a surge of panic, but Zel gently gripped her arm.

“Don’t worry. Our [Strategists], including young Olesm, say that the Goblin Lord won’t try to take the city. It’s not worth his while and he’s in a hurry. We’ll see what happens, but their walls are rebuilt thanks to the Antinium. And you. I’ll let you know if something happens.”

“Okay.”

He nodded.

“Besides that, I have a [Message] spell to send...and while I’m thinking of it, I should give you this.”

He reached for his belt and opened a bag. It must have been a bag of holding, because the small pile of gold coins clinked onto the table in a quick flow. Erin stared at them.

“What’s this? You already paid for the week, and this is way too much —”

“For the wall. And damaged chairs. Tables and so on.”

Zel looked at Erin, and shifted his gaze towards the hole in the wall. Moore opened his mouth and Jelaqua stepped on his toes. Erin stared at the gold coins and pushed them back.

“I can’t take this. It’s my fault—”

“Please.”

Zel refused to touch the coins. He stood up. Erin tried to offer them back, but he refused.

“I know what you’re trying to say, but you did what I would have done in your shoes. Better. You uncovered a real threat, and...it was not your fault. I was the highest-level warrior on the field that night. The battle was *mine* to lose. I wasn’t here. This is my way of apologizing.”

“Even so—I don’t need it. I don’t. I have enough money coming in. Lots, actually. And Ryoka left some of her gold—look, I can’t—”

Zel edged around Erin and left the inn before she could block him. Erin stood in the doorway forlornly, watching him march quickly through the snow. Jelaqua sighed and got to her feet.

“We’d probably pay if he didn’t. He’s right, you know. No one blames you for what went down, Erin. You did what you could. It’s just...”

She shrugged. Moore and Seborn were also getting to their feet. She looked at them, shook her head. Mrsha, Lyonette, Erin—Drassi poked her head out of the kitchen. Jelaqua looked tired.

“Sometimes you run into a real monster. Someone invincible. Something. Sometimes you lose. That’s the way this world works, right?”

She turned and looked around, her customary smile gone. She nodded, and the Halfseekers slowly walked out the door.

Erin stood, watching them go as well. A half-Giant, wading through snow that only came up to his ankles. Seborn, quiet as a shadow. Jelaqua, leading with head turned up to the sky. Erin stood in the quiet inn and stared at the spot where Ulrien had died. Mrsha hugged Lyonette and Apista fanned her wings by the fire.

After a while, Drassi poked her head out of the kitchen again.

“We’re out of milk, by the way.”

Life moved on.

It was the goats that saved them. Because of them, the six were granted another day to live. And they were grateful. They had to live. It was that or die, and they were too proud to die. Their friends had sacrificed too much for them to die.

But they would die soon. If not today, then tomorrow. If not tomorrow, then later. The only question was how they would die. For that was their fate.

They were Goblins. And they had no tribe. They were warriors without a purpose. They had fought and bled and half their number had died for a Human. A monster with a soul. Someone who had looked at them and seen a reflection.

And now six remained. Six Goblins. Elite warriors of the Redfang Goblin tribe, sent by Garen Redfang himself on a mission they had long since abandoned and no longer cared about.

Lost.

Last night, the Goblin Lord’s army had marched north. North, past the city of Liscor. North, towards Esthelm and the lands beyond. Their numbers were in the tens of thousands, not including the undead army that marched ahead of them. They were legion—an army to strike fear into the hearts of all but the mightiest. A Goblin Lord rode with them. A figure equivalent to any [General]. With him leading the army, they could destroy a lesser nation.

And yet, they had come under attack last night. Just once. It was as the group of six Redfang warriors were desperately hiding behind the cover of some rocks, lying low in case the patrolling sentries headed their way. They might have been found. Again, but for the goats.

Eater Goats. One of the monsters from the High Passes, a match for a Carn Wolf. These creatures were deadly, quick, fearless, and could eat anything. Their jaws could crunch stone or metal. And they hunted in packs.

A group of them had charged the Goblin Lord's army. Just over a hundred attacking tens of thousands of Goblins. But the goats were fearless. And hungry. The winter had driven them from their homes. That, and... something else perhaps. Some disturbance. Whatever the case, they had spotted a *lot* of prey, and gone rampaging into the Goblin Lord's ranks.

Hiding behind their cover, the Redfang warriors had enjoyed hearing the screams of Goblins as the Eater Goats ambushed them. The goats had taken down Hobs, chewed through armor and bitten through bone, and devoured the undead trying to kill them before retreating. Of course, the Goblin Lord's army had encircled the goats with steel, shot arrows into their hides, blasted them with magic.

It was a testament, then, to the fearsome nature of the goats that after attacking an army of tens of thousands, a little over thirty goats still escaped. And not because they'd been dying either; it was just that they'd eaten their fill.

Monsters. But their intervention had allowed the Redfang Goblins to hide in the meantime and let the Goblin Lord's army pass them by. And so the next day, the six Goblins rose and followed the Eater Goats as they headed south, searching for more food.

There was a logic to it. Despite the Eater Goats being considered a terrible threat worthy of a Gold-rank team, the Redfang Goblins knew they had little to fear from them. That was because their tribe, led by Garen Redfang, had lived in the High Passes for years and clashed with the Eater Goats many times. They were known to the Eater Goats, in short.

There were two settings the goats had. They regarded the world as made up of two things. Food and not-Food. Through bloody battles where they had slaughtered the goats, the Redfang Goblins had earned the enviable title of not-Food, allowing them to pass by the Eater Goats without incident. So long as one side or the other wasn't hungry.

The trick was red paint on their faces and bodies. All six of the Redfang warriors wore it. That combination of red and green warned the Eater Goats not to attack. Thus, the Redfang warriors could let the goats move ahead and enjoy the protection of the ravenous monsters. Afraid of Shield Spiders, Mothbears, Armored Crawlers, or Wyverns? No problem. The Eater Goats would take down anything that moved.

And in the meantime, the Redfang warriors could scavenge the kills.

The place where the Goblin Lord's army had clashed with the Eater Goats still had a few fallen bodies. The goats, having eaten last night, were all resting until their systems worked through their meals. That meant the Redfang Goblins had a short window to procure their own rations. They were hungry; they'd been in hiding for the last day from the Goblin Lord's army.

The six Goblins hurried down the pass and ran across the muddy ground, searching for fallen bodies that weren't completely rotten. It was a

miserable, horrible task, but they had to do it. It was that or starve. They were hungry enough to eat an undead Goblin, but all of them prayed it wouldn't come to that.

One of the Redfang warriors paused as he found a figure in black armor lying in the snow. He nudged the body, turned it over, and saw a fat Hob's face. Dead and still caked in mud. Skin cold from the air which still had yet to warm. Perfect.

He called the others over. Two Goblins approached. They eyed the Hob, nodded. Three lifted the huge corpse up and moved back towards their hiding spot. The other three hoisted corpses of their own and joined them.

Normally, three Goblins couldn't carry a Hob of any size, let alone a fat one with armor. But the Redfang warriors were strong. Unlike every other Goblin and some adventurers, they trained for combat. And the six who now started a fire in the snow were more different still.

Rabbiteater. Bugear. Numbtongue. Shorthilt. Badarrow. Headscratcher. They tossed wood on a growing flame, warmed their frozen bodies, and carved up the dead Goblins, roasting flesh on pans and eating greedily. Hungrily. They were *starving*. They'd been starving for days. Normally, a small Goblin could live for a week on a single body, but these Goblins consumed all they found and went back to look for more. Because they weren't small Goblins any longer.

They were Hobs.

All six. Headscratcher carved more fat and tossed it into the pan, grunting with surprise when he missed. Badarrow caught the flesh out of the air. He had been the first to grow used to his longer limbs and new musculature. He tilted the pan and the smell made Rabbiteater grunt. Badarrow flipped the meat towards him and the other Hob grabbed it out of the air.

They ate for over an hour. Because they were *hungry*. It had been a week since the Goblins had begun growing at an abnormal rate, nearly doubling their height in a matter of days, and the cost of it was reflected in sunken cheeks, thin bellies, and their craving for any food—even the bodies of their own.

Shorthilt reappeared by their fire and tossed something down. The other Hobs looked and saw it was a pack of rations for the Goblin Lord's soldiers! They were on it in a second, fighting over the hard, gritty bread and frozen bit of cheese and jerky. It didn't matter that the food was half-rotten. Goblins would eat anything in hard times, and they knew they needed all the energy they could get.

The Hobgoblin transformation process was usually like this. But as Numbtongue pointed out with an eloquent grunt after their hunger pangs had subsided, it was rare for so many Hobs to appear at once.

The other Redfang warriors considered this. Bugear scratched at his ears, a tick left over from a time when bugs had actually infested his ears. Now they were gone, which was a disappointment since he could have used more to eat. But it was also a reminder of who he'd met, of who he'd lost.

The action was both a message and a habit. The other Goblins stared at Bugear and looked away. They remembered, too.

A city full of undead. A place of ruin and shattered Humans. A monster who ate like they did. A girl, begging for help. Goblins in black armor. The [Knight]. The skeleton dancing in delight. The flowers.

Death. That was what they had left behind. The Redfang warriors stared at the fire. They'd lost so many. Their leader, the taciturn Grunter, Rocksoup, always complaining of indigestion, Leftstep, who'd once dueled a Gold-rank [Fencer] with a stick and a shield made of bark. Bitefly, who ate flies. Orangepoo, whose name spoke for itself. Patchhelm, obsessed

with armor, and Justrust, whose swords were as deadly for tetanus as they were for their ability to cut.

All gone. The Redfang warriors sat, remembering. All gone, and for what? Badarrow gnashed his teeth as he gnawed at a bone, making his feelings plain.

Headscratcher held something up. The others looked. It was a flower.

Eloquently put. Badarrow tossed the bone aside and sighed. Headscratcher ate the flower. They'd been over this too many times to count. Too many times to dwell on it, but they did.

They were alone. And they had lost their group, as well as their purpose. Or rather, their conviction. After meeting a Human, after fighting for her, perhaps loving her—how could they kill another Human? What was the point?

Shorthilt made their general position clear by tossing a bit of intestines, too filthy even by Goblin standards, into the fire. The smell made the other Goblins growl, but he was right.

Garen Redfang was wrong. He was also an idiot. Rags, their new and rightful Chieftain, was probably right. At the very least, she was smart and worth following. If they could rejoin her tribe.

But where were they? The Redfang warriors had combed the area looking for clues about where their tribe had gone. They'd tried to enter the High Passes, but found no sign of any Goblins in the area. And the danger was too great, so they'd come south, hoping to find Rags around Liscor.

However, all six knew that if the Flooded Waters tribe had been anywhere around Liscor, the Goblin Lord's army would have already destroyed them utterly.

So what now? Headscratcher scratched his head and patted his stomach. The others looked at him gloomily. Yes, the problem was obvious. Besides finding their tribe, the six warriors were in dire straits of their own. Because they were still hungry, and they would continue being hungry for a while.

They were Hobs. Six new Hobs, which shouldn't be! Most small tribes had one or two Hobs at most. Big tribes could, of course, have many Hobs—there were rumors of a tribe living in the mountains who had hundreds of Hobs, and the Goblin Lord's army had thousands. But who'd heard of six Goblins all turning into Hobs at once?

It made no sense. But it had something to do with what they'd been through, the Redfang warriors were sure. Losing Grunter, their leader and only Hob, had triggered the change, as well as the ferocity of the battle they'd been through. Normally this would be a cause for celebration; a Hob was special, and they would be far stronger for their transformation. But only if they were with their tribe. Out here, away from any support and scavenging for food in the last stages of winter?

It was a death sentence. Already, the Redfang warriors felt hungry again. Numbtongue and Rabbiteater went to look for more corpses. The rest sat and debated what to do.

It wasn't a hard decision. To the Goblins' uncomplicated minds, there was only death, and more death. To the north, there was merciless death, overwhelming death, the death of enemies from the Goblin Lord's army. They couldn't hide twice and they'd die in an instant against so many foes, Hobs or not. Surrendering to join the Goblin Lord's army was...also not an option. They'd been seen fighting at Esthelm against the Goblin Lord's army and besides that, the Redfang warriors had their pride.

South, then. The only way they could go. To Liscor. However, the Redfang Goblins were sure that meant another kind of death as well. Badarrow captured the idea by breaking a bit of ice with one hand. It would

be a death of pieces, a slow death. They'd find food or starve. Or be hunted down as threats.

Bugear nodded. He kicked dirt over their fire and Headscratcher pointed. The Eater Goats were rising, already heading southwards for more food.

Yes, it would most likely be their deaths. But what other choice did they have? They were warriors. At least this way there was a chance. And if they had to die fighting, well...

The Eater Goats ran swiftly down the rocky slopes and onto the road, moving quickly, jumping incredible heights with ease. Their teeth were still red from their feast, their hides still matted with blood. They screamed a hunting call. The Redfang warriors followed at a distance.

If they had to die, at least they'd have a worthy foe to die fighting against. They *hated* those damn goats. But, as even Badarrow would concede, they were a lot easier to fight against than Gargoyles.

“So you’re a [Farmer].”

“That is correct, Miss Solstice.”

“That’s cool. I mean, I don’t want to make assumptions. But it’s just weird. I didn’t think I’d ever uh, meet a Gnoll [Farmer]. Do you—is that normal?”

The Gnoll raised a furry eyebrow. His fur was a dirty blonde, and he’d paused in his chores long enough to chat with Erin. He shifted the empty pail as he considered her question.

“Hrm. No, I suppose it is not. My people, they do raise animals, but they do not plant, yes? However, we learned to farm the land from the Drakes, and so some of us abandon our travels to settle near cities.”

“Like Liscor. That’s what I never got. Why would anyone ever live in a village near the city? I mean, this is a nice hill you’ve got here. Very big. But...it’s, uh, a bit undefended.”

The Gnoll bared his teeth as Erin gestured to the village she stood in. It really was a small place. A pair of farms, a few houses, and a ten-foot-high wall were the only defenses. The Gnoll only shrugged.

“There is no safety anywhere, yes? So long as we do not stray beyond the walls, it is easy to defend. Hollowstone Deceivers—”

“What? Oh, you mean Rock Crabs.”

“Rock Crabs? Hrm. That is a good name for them, yes. They do not attack walled settlements. Shield Spiders are a threat if they burrow, but they can be heard tunneling. As for Goblins and other threats...I have a bow and the others in the village are able to fight. The Watch patrols in the area. It is safe, and needed.”

“Because you feed the city?”

“Exactly so. Without us, Liscor would starve. Oh, there is fishing to be done in the spring, and [Shepherds] can keep their sheep within the walls if need be. But all cities save for the Walled Cities require [Farmers].”

“Right. I gotcha. And you specialize in milk, right?”

The Gnoll nodded.

“That is so. I keep many cows. They are curious creatures, or so I think. Even after raising them for many years, I find it odd, yes? But they give milk, which my people love. You said you wished for some.”

“Oh! Right. I’d like to buy some, yeah. Krshia said she gets it from you and you were going to bring some in a day or two, but I’d like some today if you have any you can spare.”

“Certainly. It is expensive in the winter, of course—”

“I’ve got money. Don’t worry. I just need some. You see, I have this little Gnoll I’m helping to look after—”

“Mrsha. Hrr. Yes. I know.”

Erin blinked.

“You do—but—right.”

The [Farmer] smiled. He gestured towards his house.

“We have different kinds of milks, yes? Some cows give better milk. Richer, fatter...and, of course, I have had the great luck of obtaining a Fischer Cow pair. Now I have several such cows. And goats. I believe a young Gnoll would like goat milk most.”

“Goat milk? Well, I wouldn’t mind having some of—what’s a Fischer Cow?”

“They like meat. Their milk is very rich, although the cows themselves...they bite.”

The [Farmer] showed Erin a scar on one arm. She shuddered.

“Meat eating cows. What’s next?”

“I would love to have one of the magical types of cows in my barn one day. But they are rare and hard to raise, yes? For now, I have several bottles of goat milk and more. Come, please.”

Erin sneezed. It was cold, and the Gnoll’s offer was very tempting.

“Okay. I might have to make a few trips to get all the milk I want, though. I’ll buy in bulk. I have a little sled—”

“It is no issue. I will be here all day.”

“Cool. Hey, do you want to buy some honey? Lyonette got a lot last time and I thought I’d ask. Don’t know if cows eat honey, but it’s good stuff.”

“...Honey?”

“I am Bird. Bird I am. I hunt birds with my bow. This is my song. La. Lah, la...birds.”

Bird sang quietly to himself as he stood in his watch tower on top of Erin’s inn. His bow was in hand, and he was scanning the sky for birds. This was his purpose, but he was being extra alert today.

Because he had failed. Two people had died while he was on duty. True, one had died inside the inn, at the hands of a Named Adventurer, and the other had been killed in the city, but the deaths weighed on Bird.

He was a guard. A protector. Revalantor Klbkch had impressed on him the grave nature of his duty. He had been given a chance, a chance to protect Erin, to whom he and his comrades owed so much.

She had given him the bow he held. She had taught him chess. She had freed his fellow Workers. Freed them in their heads.

For that he would always love her. And he had failed her. Her guests were dead. Bird knew he didn’t understand things like Pawn did, but he understood failure.

So he stood in his watch tower, ignoring the cold. He hunted for birds. He would hunt for birds and that would make things better. One bird, two birds...if it took him a thousand birds, he would shoot them all down. That was the only way he knew how to make things better.

Bird didn't know much about the world. He knew some things were bad. Some things he had to watch out for. Rock Crabs, Shield Spiders, Face-Eater Moths...these things weren't birds, so the Antinium only identified them as threats. The world was hard and complex.

Not like birds. There were blue birds and red birds, yellow birds and black birds. There were birds that flew high, birds who could fly through the clouds thousands of miles overhead. The Antinium was still trying to figure out how he was going to shoot them down.

There were birds who could fly faster than the wind. Birds who were larger than houses. Birds who flew through the sky and left trails of glowing air in their wake. Birds that were beauty and wrath, elegance and cunning.

They flew. Bird could still remember the wonder he'd felt the first time he'd looked up and seen a bird flying. The envy. And he could remember shooting one. He hunted birds because he was jealous. Because they were beautiful. Because they were food.

Because he loved to hunt. And if you had a bow, what was the point of shooting at slow things on the ground? The masters of the sky were true challenges, from the tiny birds that could dodge an arrow's tip at point blank range, to the big birds that might take a full quiver to down.

Bird had an arrow in one of his hands as he scanned the horizon. Check for birds, check for threats. He looked up, and then down. No birds in the sky. But they'd be coming soon. His [Hunter] instincts told him so. The world was warming, and that meant food for the birds and a time for mating, nesting. He just had to wait.

Look up—a flicker behind one of the clouds, about two thousand and three hundred feet up. A bit too high to shoot. Look down. Bird saw something move. He turned and stared.

“Goats.”

There were about thirty of them. They surged across the snow, screaming. Bird could see their bodies covered with blood; one of them looked like it was missing half its face, but it didn’t seem bothered. Another had an arrow sticking out of its side. Bird thought about that.

“Goats. Goats are an animal. They are not monsters. Therefore, they are no threat.”

Satisfied with that conclusion, he turned to resume scanning the landscape when he noticed something.

“The goats are going in the same direction as Miss Solstice. Towards the farming village.”

He stared at the distant hilltop. At the goats. At the one missing half its jaw. Bird shrugged.

“Goats are food. Can you milk a goat? I will ask later.”

Again, he was about to turn, when he spotted something else. A group of six, crossing the snowy plains. They were distant, but Bird’s eyes were enhanced thanks to his [Eagle Eyes] Skill. He liked it because it was based off a bird. And what he saw made him pause.

“Green. Goblins.”

Six of them, all moving fast. They all had weapons, if not armor, and they were larger than the average Goblin. Bird thought and amended his analysis.

“Hobgoblins.”

He paused, arrow in hand. Bird watched the Goblins running, and slowly opened his mandibles.

“Goblins. Goblins are a monster. They are a threat. However, Erin’s sign says not to kill Goblins.”

That was a paradox. Bird scratched at his head and brightened.

“Ah. It said nothing about Hobgoblins.”

He put the arrow to his bow. Halrac had taught him how to shoot. Bird was grateful. He wished the Goblins were birds. That would make things so much more fun. Land-based things were so...*easy*.

The Goblins were over eight hundred feet away, a vast distance and far further than his bow was capable of shooting. Normally. Bird had no idea about technical terms like draw strength, the materials used in the composition of his bow, and so on—he didn’t know that it was a recurve bow. But he did know how to hunt birds. He knew that an arrow might not pierce a bird if it was shot from too far away.

“That is what Skills are for. Now. [Long Range Shot].”

He pulled the arrow back, sighted, and *loosed*.

The Redfang warriors were arguing and split on their argument. They’d followed the Eater Goats down the abandoned road, and they had seen the goats pick up a scent. They saw the village the goats were headed towards, and half of them were in favor of waiting for the goats to do their work, and the other half were in favor of helping. Somehow.

None of them were under any illusions. The Eater Goats outnumbered them and they were deadly. One could kill an average Hob. Six versus thirty wasn't a fight, it was a death sentence.

And yet, Headscratcher insisted it wasn't *right*. And however much Badarrow and Shorthilt snarled at him, he was growing more impatient. The Goblins were running after the Eater Goats anyways; they'd have a brief window to loot the village regardless of what happened. Headscratcher was cresting a hill when Bugear looked up in alarm and tackled him to the ground.

An arrow whistled through the air, catching Headscratcher in the arm. If Bugear hadn't pushed him, it would have caught him in the chest. The Redfang Goblins immediately dove to the ground. Badarrow snarled as he grabbed his own bow and raised his head.

Where? The Goblins looked around, keeping low, aware that their position might be open. Headscratcher snapped the arrow in his arm, raised his head, and then ducked down.

Nothing that way. Rabbiteater crawled rapidly to the left and looked around a small rise of snow. He growled.

Nothing.

As Numbtongue raised his head over the hill, all six Hobs heard another whistling sound. Numbtongue ducked, and the second arrow nearly took him in the head. He snarled, and all six Goblins poked their heads up. They looked around, but only Badarrow with his enhanced eyes spotted anything. He pointed.

There!

The Goblins looked. All six ducked. The archer in the tower's next arrow *thunked* into the ground that was giving them cover.

A lightning-fast debate with hand signs took place as the Hobgoblins analyzed the situation, and then, as Bird was waiting for them to pop up again, all six suddenly stood up.

“What is this?”

The Antinium stared at the six very helpful targets that had suddenly appeared. He shrugged, not deciding to question it since they weren’t birds, and aimed for the one he’d hit first. He sighted down his bow, and then jerked back.

An arrow streaked past his head, shattering on one of the wooden posts of his tower. Bird stared at the broken fragments as they splintered past him, and then at the Goblin in the distance holding the bow.

Badarrow grinned savagely. His best three arrows were in his hand. He nocked the first, aimed, and loosed.

[Farshot Mastery]. He’d learned the Skill after sniping the Goblin [Shaman] during the battle at Esthelm. Unlike Bird, he could shoot as many arrows as quickly as he wanted, uninhibited by a need to use a certain Skill. Badarrow advanced, loosing all three arrows in succession.

As he did, the Redfang warriors advanced. Not at a run, but at a quick walk. Those of them with shields had them raised. They were waiting for a return shot.

When it came, it was straight at Badarrow. The Hobgoblin [Archer] grunted, and stepped sideways. The arrow flashed by his chest, scoring a line and making him growl. But it was a miss.

Advance. Badarrow’s shots came three at a time, flying with incredible accuracy to land on Bird’s position. The Antinium took cover by the stairwell, wishing he’d asked for a place to take cover from enemy fire

when the Antinium had built this place. But *birds* didn't shoot back! Well, most of them didn't.

When he rose, an arrow struck him in the chest. Bird stumbled back, stared at the arrow, and touched it gently.

"Ow."

The other archer might have been able to hit him at range, but his bow wasn't good. It didn't have the power to pierce his carapace with a single shot. That knowledge was important. Bird looked and saw the Redfang Goblins had covered over two hundred feet while the other archer kept him suppressed. They were advancing quickly now.

"Troublesome."

He aimed and used [Long Range Shot] again, but the Goblins were a bit too *quick*, and his arrows had to travel too far. He grazed one on the arm, and nearly got one on the eye until a lucky shot hit one in the knee. That Goblin fell, rolling until he was obscured in the snow. Bird ignored him. The real threat was hitting his tower now, concentrating on volume rather than accuracy.

Two more arrows struck the Antinium. They were both in each other's range now, and the second and third arrows penetrated his carapace. Bird fumbled with an arrow. He could not die here. If he did...he would have failed again. Unacceptable.

"My turn."

The arrow was coming. All five Hobs tensed. Shorthilt was hiding in the snow, and he had a healing potion. He'd make it back to them if he could, but the arrows were fast and deadly. The next one came fast and high at Badarrow. The Hob twisted to avoid it, grinning—

And the arrow *curved* into his side. Greatly surprised, Badarrow spun. Headscratcher caught Badarrow as he nearly fell. The Goblin gripped him, pulled himself upright—

The next homing arrow struck Bugear's shield. It had curved right for Badarrow's head. The Redfang Goblins looked at the distant archer. Badarrow snarled as he grabbed arrows from his bow. Whoever this strange bug was, he was *good*.

And yet, he was only one. Bird had to take cover again as arrows lashed his position. The Goblin didn't have his curving arrows, but he was quick! Bird peeked up, and an arrow nearly took his eye out.

"Dangerous."

They were too close now. Too close! Bird had to risk a shot. This time he'd hit the archer in the head! He stood and took a fourth arrow to the chest.

"Ah."

The cracks in his carapace were spreading. Bird fell against one of the guard railings of his tower, and lurched upright. One arrow. He drew it to his chest, sighted. Time felt slow. He aimed at the Goblin. They both were aiming. The one who fell won. He could take the other Goblins down if he could just—

Where to aim? Head, chest—head. Bird drew, and spoke as he loosed.

"[Homing Shot]."

His arrow *curved* through the air, heading straight for Badarrow's head. The Goblin archer sighted down his bow, aiming for Bird. He didn't move. The arrow flew towards his head—

And Headscratcher's sword shot out. The Goblin's sword blocked the shaft as Bugear thrust his shield in front of Badarrow's chest and Numbtongue covered his groin with a second shield. Bird stared.

"Companions. I see. How regr—"

The fifth arrow struck him just below the neck and sent him tumbling off the side of the tower. The Antinium crashed into the roof of the inn and slid towards the end. It was a long drop down. Down—

To oblivion.

In the silence after the pitched archery duel, Badarrow lowered his bow, arms shaking, breathing heavily. The other Goblins clapped him on the back as they patched themselves up.

None of them were hurt that badly. Badarrow's stomach and Shorthilt's knee were the worst of it. A healing potion was very carefully used to mend both wounds.

As the Goblins regrouped, they moved away from the inn. Whatever the archer had been doing up there, it didn't matter. The bug was dead, but no one was going to loot the inn. It was too close to the city—the Goblins might have already been spotted. They headed in the direction of the Eater Goats, hungry and desperate.

They spoke not a word about their victory either. It wasn't a miracle, or a product of Badarrow's superior levels or Skills. It was simple teamwork. Both sides had good archers, but one had located their attacker together, covered their archer, and provided targets to distract the enemy. They didn't fight alone.

Meanwhile, in a small village, Erin was dragging her sled towards the gates. Several huge containers had been filled with different kinds of milks and she was wondering if she'd be able to get it to her inn without breaking any of them.

She was rechecking the ties on her sled when she heard a sound outside the gates. Erin frowned and stepped up onto the platform that allowed her to peek over the walls. She looked down and saw a goat standing outside.

“Hey Mister Wirclaw! I think one of your goats got outside somehow!”

Erin turned and hollered at the Gnoll [Farmer] who'd helped her pack the milk. He frowned and trotted over with his son, a small Gnoll with light blonde fur. Both Gnolls peeked over the walls with Erin.

“That is not my goat.”

“You sure?”

“Yes. I know them all and this one is clearly wild. It is strange, though, no? Where would such a goat come from in the winter?”

“Should we let it in? It looks hungry, poor guy.”

“Perhaps. But...hrm. Is...something wrong?”

Erin frowned. She felt it too. A prickling at the back of her mind. She looked at the goat. It was staring up at her with big, off-putting brown eyes. The pupils of the goat were a horizontal bar, not round at all. And it was staring. At her.

“Yeah. I think I feel my [Dangersense] going off. But it's just a goat, right?”

Wirclaw hesitated. He looked back towards his house and nudged his son.

“Fetch me my bow. Miss Solstice, perhaps you should back up. I do not think that is—”

Then they spotted the second goat. It walked around the wall. It was a goat. Scrawny, its body a mix of black and brown. However, one thing separated it from the other goat.

It was missing the lower half of its jaw. Erin clapped a hand to her mouth as the goat looked up at them.

“Its *teeth*—”

This goat had sharp teeth. Not sharp like a shark’s or a predator that just ate meat, but an omnivore’s teeth. And caught between the teeth and staining it was—

“Blood. And that is flesh. Miss Solstice, step back.”

Wirclaw grabbed the bow from his son’s hands and put an arrow to it. He sighted and shot an arrow before Erin could protest. The goat without a jaw watched as the arrow sped towards it and skipped to one side. The arrow *thudded* into the dirt.

Both Human and Gnolls stared. Behind them, the few Gnolls and Drakes in the village were gathering. The two goats stared at Wirclaw and then turned.

And then a lot of goats popped out of the snow. Erin recoiled and Wirclaw *growled*. The goats gazed at Erin and Wirclaw, and then *screamed*.

It wasn’t like a Human scream. Not at all. The Eater Goats screamed like a chorus of the damned, and then the first one rammed the gates. It had

a set of slightly curved horns on its head and Wirclaw yanked Erin back from the wall.

“They’re trying to get in!”

He shouted at the others in the village and Erin saw them racing to get weapons. She scrabbled at her own belt pouches and pulled out a vial and a knife from a sheath at her belt.

“They can’t though, right?”

“The gates are thick. We should be fine—”

Wirclaw was aiming and loosing, but the goats were dodging. One of them backed up, its eyes on the Gnoll. It took a few jumps back, and then brayed. It charged towards the wall the Gnoll and Erin were standing on.

“It can’t get up—”

Erin was saying that when the goat *leapt*. It cleared at least *seven* feet and thudded into the wall. Too low. But the impact sent both Human and Gnoll scrambling backwards.

“Okay, they can jump! *Real high!*”

Erin was shouting. Wirclaw opened his mouth. He might have been saying that their walls were still high enough when two more goats charged forwards.

This time one goat leapt first. He vaulted into the air, a good six feet up, and the second goat leapt on *top* of him. He jumped a second time, using the first goat as a stepping stone, and hurtled over the wall.

The goat landed lightly on the ground in the center of the village. It turned, and stared around at the small gathering of Drakes, Gnolls, and one Human. It cocked its head, seemed to sniff, and then bared its teeth. It screamed, and *charged*.

The Goblins saw all of it, of course. From their position, the Redfang Goblins could see the first Eater Goat clear the wall and hear the screams from within the village. They had predicted that would happen. The Eater Goats were suicidally fearless and almost immune to pain; that didn't mean they were stupid.

Now they had a choice to make. Headscratcher stared at the village. He'd seen a young woman on the walls. A Human.

He looked at the others. They'd all seen the same thing. The Hobs looked at him, and then away. Badarrow spat. He'd made his position clear several times. It wasn't worth it. They'd die, and she'd die. And for what? She was just a Human.

Just a Human. The other Goblins reluctantly agreed. It wasn't the same. She wasn't worth it.

And she would die. Headscratcher lowered his head and scuffed at the snow. His foot unearthed something. He stared, bent, and picked something up. The other Goblins paused. They turned, incredulously, to Headscratcher and saw him holding—

A bug. It squirmed in his grip. He popped it into his mouth and crunched it. The Goblins all sighed. Headscratcher grinned. He cracked his neck and laughed silently at them, to ask them what they'd been expecting. He pointed.

The other Eater Goats were trying to repeat the trick and send their friends over the walls. Just one or two could wipe out the entire village. They'd kill everything within. They were too dangerous.

They all knew it. Fighting thirty? They'd die.

And maybe that was the point. Headscratcher reached into a small pocket he'd sewn into his clothing. He pulled something out. It was wilted, squashed, barely recognizable. But it was still a flower.

The other Goblins stared at it. Headscratcher looked at Badarrow. The other Goblin grunted irritably and pulled out an arrow. Headscratcher grinned.

Bugear scratched at one ear and nudged Shorthilt. They pulled out their swords. Rabbiteater lifted Grunter's axe. Numbtongue sighed.

The Redfang Goblins slapped each other on the backs, grinned, and shook hands. They looked at the sky. Then they formed up.

They didn't have the numbers for a proper formation. They couldn't swarm their opponents. So they made a line. Badarrow raised his bow and put his best arrow to the string. He loosed one arrow, then another.

The Eater Goats were charging, trying to jump the walls again. The first arrow struck a goat in the back of the head. It dropped, and then stood up. The goat looked around for the source of the arrow, saw the Redfang Goblins. It bleated, a terrible, elongated scream, and the other goats turned. One seized the arrow in the first goat's head and bit it off. The goat convulsed as the arrow was torn out of its head. At last it fell down.

And the Eaters charged. The goats raced towards the Redfang Goblins, screaming, a few staying behind to circle the village. The Redfang Goblins waited.

"Redfang!"

Badarrow shouted the word as he drew and loosed. He was running out of arrows. But he kept shooting, sending each one of his precious arrows

into the mass of goats. His aim was flawless today. One by one they fell, but there were so many and they were *fast!*

“Redfang!”

The other Hobs shouted the word. The Eaters screamed. Headscratcher looked at his friends, and they looked back. It wasn’t a decision he’d made alone. They’d all made it.

It wasn’t about living. It was about dying right. It was about finding somewhere to die. Because they didn’t have anything to live for. They had no tribe, no leader. They just had each other.

And a memory. Of a girl, of a plea. And of that glorious, terrible moment when they had been something more than mere Goblins.

This is a story of a band of Goblins. A shattered, lost collection of souls. Dreamers, warriors who had tasted something else. This is a story about *heroes*.

Badarrow reached for another arrow and found none. He tossed his bow aside. Twenty goats remained. They screamed and charged. The Goblins did likewise. Six against twenty. Death.

Not one Goblin hesitated. The Redfang warriors raised their weapons and ran forwards. They were *laughing*.

And the young woman heard it.

4.34

Six Goblins. Twenty goats. It wasn't a heroic battle, the kind you'd hear about in stories. It wasn't one anyone would celebrate or long remember. But it *was* a proper Goblin's battle. Close, intense, and perhaps meaningless. But the Goblins fought as if it were the battle to end all battles.

Because it was that or die. And while this might be the place that they *did* die, so long as one Goblin was standing, the Redfang warriors refused to fall.

Headscratcher's weapon was a shortsword. It had been a regular sword before he'd been a Hob. Now it stabbed into a goat's side and his other hand was free, so he grabbed the goat and pulled it onto the blade, spearing it.

It kept moving. The Eater Goats were inhumanly tough, which was understandable, but they were also tougher than any goat had a right to be. They swarmed the six Goblins, and it was only their teamwork that kept the Redfang warriors alive in the first charge.

Stand in a circle. Keep moving—defend each other's backs, watch the flanks. The Redfang warriors had fought hundreds of battles like this, and they slashed at the goats, keeping them at bay while they tried to score a critical blow.

Fast. The goats leapt and weathered cuts with their bodies, screaming, darting in to try and bite a leg or arm. Have one on you and it wouldn't let go until it had eaten you or died, Headscratcher knew.

He spun and kicked as, beside him, Bugar punched a goat into the ground and hacked at it. The goat Headscratcher was aiming at glanced off his leg, and he slashed futilely at it as it bounded away.

Too slow! Headscratcher raged against his own weakness as he took a step back, watching three goats circle around him, all waiting to pounce. This wasn't right. He was stronger than before! But his body was so very weak. He was hungry. Headscratcher fought the feeling down. A weak Hob was still stronger than a Goblin.

A goat leapt at the same time as two of its companions. Headscratcher dodged the first and knocked the second away with his sword, but the third bore him to the ground. He shouted as its gaping mouth was suddenly inches away from his face, biting—

Someone pulled the goat off him. Headscratcher rolled away and saw Bugar hurling the Eater Goat to one side. The other Hobgoblin never saw the second goat until it had leapt on his back. He whirled, and there was a brief flash of metal, a ripping motion, a spray of blood. The Eater goat leapt away, and Bugar stumbled.

His throat was missing.

Headscratcher rose. A goat charged him. He kicked it. Bugar was stumbling, swinging weakly. He fell. Headscratcher ran forwards as Badarrow and Shorthilt charged into the goats, screaming, and scattered them.

He caught Bugar. Headscratcher looked into his friend's eyes as Bugar clutched at the remains of his throat. The other Goblin met his gaze and squeezed his hand, then turned. He grabbed his blade and rose. An Eater Goat fell as he drove the blade into its side. Bugar made a sound as his ruined throat bubbled with blood. He charged into the goats, mouth open in a silent scream.

So many. The formation was lost. Badarrow snarled as he slashed at a goat, a dagger in one hand, a shortsword in the other. Headscratcher ran after Bugear as the Hobgoblin was swarmed. No, *no!*

Headscratcher threw one goat to the ground and stomped on it. The goat broke. He turned and another caught his arm. It bit down to the bone and tore a chunk away as Headscratcher raised his sword. He knocked the goat away and speared it to the ground with his sword.

The Hob turned and *roared*. The goats ran towards him and he cut them down. One. Two. Three. He was burning with rage. But the goats kept on coming. They were fearless. And he—

Something knocked him to the ground. Headscratcher fell. A goat was on top of him, and he was fighting it. And then he heard a whistling sound, heard and felt the *thunk*. The goat stiffened on top of him and he pushed it away.

A knife was buried in the goat's back. Headscratcher looked around. Who had thrown it? He saw a girl, standing in the melting snow, staring at him. Then she raised a hand.

“This way! *Hurry!*”

The Hobs looked up. Five of them, now. The Eater Goats were savaging Bugear. They all saw the girl and there was a second of hesitation. Just a second. Then they ran, and the goats followed.

“*Watch out!*”

Erin was the first to react after the first Eater Goat leapt the walls. She hurled her knife and the goat *dodged*. It skipped left and the blade bounced

off the ground. Then it ran at Erin, screaming.

“To the houses! Lock the doors!”

Wirclaw loosed an arrow at the goat. It pierced the goat’s side, making it stumble, but the goat came on. The other villagers ran for the doors. A few raced out as the rest barricaded themselves in, holding pitchforks, a cleaver, a rake—

“Take this!”

Erin had a small vial in one hand. She hurled it, and the goat caught it in the face this time. The vial *exploded* as it broke on impact, and the miniature fireball roasted Erin’s face. She yelped, turned, and ran. That was wise, because after a second the goat charged out of the flames. It was burning, and part of its face had been blown away. *But it was still coming.*

“*Monster!*”

A huge furry hand caught the goat as it leapt for Erin. Wirclaw hurled the goat to one side and both he and Erin rushed over. Before the goat could get up they kicked and stomped on it. They only stepped back when it stopped moving.

“Dead gods.”

Wirclaw bent over the goat, chest heaving, eyes wide. He had clearly never seen anything like it before. Erin looked towards the walls and scrambled for her knife lying on the ground.

“More are coming! Hurry!”

She and Wirclaw ran up to the watch post above the walls again. This time Wirclaw loosed arrows as fast as he could, aiming at the goats before they could perform their jumping trick. Erin was with him, another small

vial in hand. She'd only thought to bring two! She saw the goats breaking away, leaving only six or so of their number behind. Why?

Then she heard the laughter. It was fierce, distant. She turned, and saw the Goblins.

Hobgoblins. They stood in a line, six of them. One was loosing arrows at the Eater Goats; the others were waiting for the goats to charge. Wirclaw spotted them and lowered his bow for an instant in astonishment.

"Goblins? Why are they here?"

"I don't know. I think they're—helping us?"

"Impossible."

The Gnoll shook his head, but Erin was sure. She grabbed Wirclaw's arm.

"Yes! They're drawing the goats away!"

"They will be slaughtered. These goats are monsters!"

The Gnoll pointed to one of the goats below. The horrible thing had eight arrows lodged in its side, but it was still running about, bleating and screaming. Erin stared at the goats. She stared at the Goblins. Then she uncorked the second vial. Wirclaw recoiled as a viscous smell rose from the vial.

"What is *that*?"

"Acid. Octavia makes it. It's strong, so keep back. And cover me."

Erin walked down and went to the gates. She unbarred them with one hand as Wirclaw roared at her. The gates opened, and the villagers behind Erin shouted as the six goats charged her.

Erin raised the vial in her hand. She tossed the acid onto the faces of the first two goats who ran towards her, and raised her fist.

“[Minotaur Punch]!”

Another goat went flying. The remaining three were outnumbered, and the villagers charged them, weapons raised. The danger was in their numbers as much as their insane resistance to damage! Erin ran out of the gates, hearing Wirclaw’s arrows *thunk* into the ground behind her. She turned and saw the Hobgoblins fighting for their lives. And behind them—something else.

Erin stared at the distant figures and waved her hands. She pointed once, and ran towards the goats and Goblins. She hoped they’d gotten the message.

Now.

They all ran. The Human girl, the young woman, waved her arms once and then raced away. Not towards the village, but just away, through the snow. The Goblins followed her, because they had no other choice.

The goats gave them a few seconds of lead as they fought over Bugear and their comrades. Then, sensing their prey might get away, the rest turned and ran.

There were eleven or so now, all injured, but Eater Goats never gave up. And they were quick! Headscratcher turned as one raced behind him. He shouted, and Badarrow twisted. The goat bounced off his raised arm. Numbtongue spat as he lifted one of the two swords in his hands and threw it. The goats dodged around the sword, slowing them down.

Now Numbtongue was down a sword. That meant he ran faster. The Hobgoblins were nearly caught up with the girl, and so were the goats. She was floundering in the snow. Headscratcher turned, ready to fight, to die—

An arrow shot past his head. It curved *around* Rabbiteater who was in the rear and struck a goat in the head. The goat dropped. His buddies halted and looked around.

On a snow-covered hilltop sixty feet away, Bird lowered his bow and reached for another arrow. He fumbled as he grasped for it, and his fingers brushed one of the newly-healed wounds on his chest.

“Ow.”

“Are you okay?”

Beside him, Lyonette turned anxiously. She and Drassi were standing in the snow. So was Mrsha, despite Lyonette’s attempts to keep her in the inn. All three had potions and other alchemist weapons in their hands. Bird nodded.

“I believe the arrowhead of one of the arrows is lodged in my carapace. It will not bother me when shooting.”

As he spoke he loosed another arrow. This one caught a goat leaping for Erin’s legs. It fell too.

Erin and the Goblins were all running towards them. Lyonette gulped. She turned to Drassi.

“Ready? When they come—*throw!*”

The Drake was pale-faced but she nodded. Mrsha lifted a bottle and Lyonette would have grabbed it if her hands weren’t full, too. More arrows were flying from the direction of the village, but the suicidal goats *kept coming*.

“Erin! This way! *Duck!*”

Lyonette waited until Erin and the Hobgoblins were twenty feet away before throwing. Drassi threw at the same time. The Human girl and Hobgoblins covered their heads and ducked as they ran. The Eater Goats looked up and saw two vials spinning towards them through the air—

They turned as the vials plopped into the snow and exploded into crackling lightning and a shower of thorny spines several feet away. Bird stared at the [Barmaids] as he reached for another arrow. And then Mrsha tossed.

Her aim was good. Her arm was terrible. The red vial with a shining orange center spun lazily down, just above one goat. It would have missed. Would have, but the goat, eternally hungry, leapt up and *bit* the vial in midair.

It exploded. Fire and bits of goat rained down. The other goats scattered, and then backed away as Mrsha, Lyonette, and Drassi threw again.

A tripvine bag exploded, catching two goats in the thorny tendrils that raced along the ground. A vial of pepper potion was swallowed by a goat that hadn’t learned the lesson the first time. That goat rolled around, shrieking. And Lyonette’s vial of Silverfrost missed everything and exploded into a frozen cloud next to the Hobgoblins.

Bird loosed an arrow. Erin turned. She had no knives, but she raised her fists anyways. The five Hobgoblins turned. They saw two goats tangled up in vines, chewing their way out, one rolling around on the ground, and a final goat, charging at them and bleating.

The final goat stopped. It looked back and saw a trail of its fallen friends, arrows sticking out of their heads, a flaming bit of snow where one

of its friends had exploded, and another goat riddled with arrows from Wirclaw. It looked at the Hobs.

To its credit, it didn't hesitate as it charged. The Hobs cut it down in moments and then turned to the three immobilized goats. They butchered all three with swift, precise blows.

And then it was over. Erin bent, panting, forehead covered with sweat despite the cold air. The Hobgoblins stood, blades dripping with gore, staring at each other and the odd company on the hilltop. Bird carefully drew another arrow and aimed it at Badarrow.

“Are you okay?”

Erin said it first to Lyonette, and then to the Goblins. They stared at her. Lyonette was the one who spoke.

“I—we're okay, Erin. We found Bird lying on the ground a few minutes ago and he told us there were Goblins—we saw the goats attacking the village from a distance and came here. But what—”

“Goblins? Wait, why was Bird—”

“They shot me, Miss Erin. I regret to inform you that I did not manage to kill any of them. However, that may be good since your rule stipulates not killing Goblins. However, they are *Hobgoblins* so I did try. But they had better teamwork and so I was shot and fell off the roof. It was quite painful, but fortunately Miss Lyonette had healing potions.”

Bird calmly aimed at Badarrow as he spoke. Erin's eyes widened and she looked at the Hobs. They glanced at each other and Shorthilt covered his face as Badarrow glowered at Bird.

“Wait, but they *saved* me! I mean, the village we were in was under attack by those goats. Why did they attack you, Bird?”

The Antinium hesitated. He looked at the Goblins and they, remembering, glared back. Bird didn't exactly meet Erin's eyes. He shuffled his feet before he spoke.

"I may have tried to shoot them from afar."

He glanced at Erin and hunched his shoulders.

"I *am* supposed to hunt monsters."

"But they're Goblins! Wait—"

Erin closed her eyes as she held up a hand. Everyone looked at her. She took a breath.

"Okay. I think I get it. Lower your bow, Bird."

"What? *Erin!*"

"It's okay, Lyonette. Trust me. Bird, lower your bow. These Goblins aren't going to attack. Right?"

She glanced over her shoulder. The Hobgoblins blinked at her, and then edged away from her and the others. They glanced back across the snowy plains. One of them took a step away.

"Wait—"

They turned to look back at Erin. The Goblins stared at her, and one raised a hand. Drassi screamed and Mrsha hid behind Erin as the Hob who'd raised the hand glanced at her. He turned away.

"Ancestors, Ancestors, *oh Ancestors—*"

"Drassi!"

Lyonette grabbed the shaking Drake. Drassi had faced down the Eater Goats despite her fears, but close proximity to the Hobgoblins was making

the Drake tremble like a leaf. Erin called out after the Goblins as they trudged away, and then saw a group of Gnolls and Drakes heading her way.

“Uh oh. I’d better deal with that—come on!”

The others followed her as she jogged through the snow. The villagers led by Wirclaw caught up with her, holding bloody weapons. None of them were hurt, which was a relief. Wirclaw half-raised his bow as he spotted Bird, and then glanced towards the Hobs in the distance.

“Miss Erin! Are you unharmed? Why did you leave? Those Goblins—”

“They saved your village, Wirclaw. No, don’t argue about it. Look, Lyonette and Mrsha and Drassi here helped you all. Can you take them back to your village for a little bit? I want to bring back the milk with them, and I think Drassi needs to sit down.”

“Certainly, but—”

Erin turned to Bird, ignoring the Gnoll.

“Bird, you go with them. Keep your bow out just in case I guess, but don’t shoot anyone unless they attack! Got it?”

The Antinium nodded. He looked at Erin.

“And what will you do, Miss Solstice?”

Erin squared her shoulders and then twisted her neck with a grimace. She must have twisted something while she was running or fighting. A healing potion would sort that out. But first things first. She turned and looked towards the five Goblins. They were standing around the spot where they’d first fought the goats. There had been six of them, then. Erin nodded to the Goblins and looked around at everyone staring at her.

“I’m going to talk to them.”

Bugear lay on the ground. Or rather, what remained of him lay there. Most of his body was gone but his head had been mostly spared from the savaging. Headscratcher knelt in the muddy ground and snow and picked it up. Bugear's expression had slackened in death, but Headscratcher could still remember his wordless snarl as he charged the Eater Goats.

He had known he wouldn't survive, so he'd thrown himself into the fighting to distract the goats. It had bought them enough time to survive. The other Goblins knew it. They stood around Bugear in silence.

There were no recriminations. No words of reproach for Headscratcher, or indeed, no words of any kind. It was done. They'd fought and now they were fewer. Again.

Redfang warriors did not weep for the fallen. They were warriors; they knew what their fates were. They did not cry, because their leader, Garen Redfang, didn't believe in it. So the five Goblins did not weep for their brother.

"Um, hello?"

A timid voice interrupted their moment of silence. The Goblins turned. Headscratcher wiped at his eyes that weren't full of tears. He stopped and stared.

A girl stood in the snow. The same girl who'd helped save them, the one whom they'd seen on the walls of the village. She stared at them. How could she know what thought was running through their minds? What memories, what tragedies?

There were no words. And Redfang warriors did not weep. So the others brushed a bit of sweat, maybe melted snow water from their eyes as

they looked at her. She was Human, an enemy most of the times, prey others. But they had met one who was neither. Once.

How could she know? She couldn't. But the young woman saw their tears. And because she stood in front of them without a sword or spell blazing in her hands, they listened. The Redfang warriors had no hope of anything in particular. They were just lost and very tired.

And the young woman looked at them, at the head in Headscratcher's arms, and did something they had never seen a Human do before.

She bowed.

"Thank you."

Erin bowed to the five Goblins. The snow was stained red, and when she raised her head, she saw they had mostly wiped their tears away. The five Goblins stared at her. She said it again.

"Thank you. You saved us. I owe you my life."

Silence. The Goblins looked at each other. Erin looked at them.

Five Goblins. Five...Hobs. She had only ever met two Hobs before in her life. Erin remembered the Goblin Chieftain, a lifetime ago, and the other Hob who she had met with Rags. These five were not like either.

They were ragged. They had loincloths, ill-fitting pieces of armor that were too small on their bodies, and weapons. Their blades were well looked after, but obviously well-used as well. Erin thought they were good iron, rather than steel.

And each of the Hobgoblins was injured. One, the one carrying the head, had a huge chunk taken out of his arm and a bad gash down one leg, but he didn't seem to notice the blood running from him. Erin did.

“Thank you.”

She said it a third time, mostly because she had no idea of what to say next. The Goblins looked at her, and then each other. One, the only Goblin carrying a bow, growled and turned away.

“I'm sorry about your friend.”

The other Goblins looked at Erin, and then at the head of their companion. They said not a word. Another Goblin broke away from Erin. The rest just stared at her as if they'd never met a Human before. Or rather, never talked to a Human before.

“Uh—”

What could she say? Thanks? She'd said that. I'm sorry? Ditto. Erin didn't know *what* she should do. The Goblins had saved her. If they were anyone else—a group like the Horns of Hammerad for instance—she would have offered them money, asked where they were from and so on. But these Goblins...

One of them, the one with the bow, was retrieving arrows from the goats and butchering them at the same time. He glanced up and growled something at the others. Two more broke away and began helping him. His look was the least friendly as he stared at Erin.

“Are you...hungry?”

That was the only explanation Erin could think of. The goat meat didn't look good and she would have bet it was stringy, but the Goblins were cutting them up quickly. Her words made the Goblin with the bow look up. This time he rolled his eyes.

“Okay, I got *that*. You’re hungry. Do you want something to eat?”

Five growling stomachs answered her. Erin stared at the Goblins. She knew she shouldn’t. She knew it might be a bad idea. But they were staring at her, and there was nothing simple in their eyes. One of them, the Goblin cradling the head of their friend, was staring at her like—like—

“Would you like to come with me? I have food to eat. You can have it. Free. You don’t have to pay.”

It popped out of her mouth, and once said, it was impossible to take back. The Goblins all turned. The one with the bow straightened. The one with the head dropped it, and then scrambled to pick it up.

“I—I have an inn.”

Erin felt she should explain as the Goblins looked at her. She pointed, and they stared across the rolling snow-covered hills towards her inn in the distance. They exchanged a look.

“You can go there if you’re hungry. I have food. Lots of food. And you could bury your friend...”

Erin’s voice trailed off. The Goblins were just staring at her. There was nothing hostile about their gazes, but they were so bewildered. So lost. She coughed.

“You know what? Meet me there. No one will hurt you, I promise. I’ll have food. You don’t *have* to come, but if you do...food, okay?”

She mimed walking to her inn. The Goblins stared at her. One nodded. Erin stopped pretending to walk, feeling silly. They weren’t *stupid*. Rags had never been stupid. If she were here, she would have been rolling her eyes, making rude gestures and telling Erin she got it already.

But she wasn't. So Erin pointed again, and slowly backed away. Then she went to find Lyonette and the others.

"We might be having guests in a bit. You all okay?"

They stared at her. Erin pointed at her sled, still carrying all the milk she'd bought.

"Come on, let's go back. Bird, I'll pull the sled. Mrsha can ride on it. Let's go."

She turned and pulled by momentum more than anything else, her employees and Mrsha following. Erin walked slowly back to her inn, hearing Drassi burst out into nervous chatter after a while and Lyonette soothing Mrsha. But her eyes were on the Goblins all the while. And when she made it to her inn and paused at the open doorway, she could tell they were still watching her.

In the Redfang tribe, stories were still told of Garen Redfang and how their Chieftain had once walked through Human cities, often wearing a mask and a hood to conceal his features. He had spoken with Humans and other species, traded with them, and fought as a Gold-rank adventurer for a time. More than a few Goblins had dreamed of doing the same, but only dreamed.

It was a legend, a myth. No real Goblin would ever walk through a city unless they were there to be executed, or if their tribe was raiding it. And while the Redfang warriors had entered Human dwellings before, they had never gone into one without swords in hand.

Now they stood outside of an inn just a short distance away from Liscor and stared up at it. Not one of the five Goblins had a sword in their hands. It was a surreal experience. Headscratcher hesitated at the wooden door to the inn for several minutes before he pushed it open. Numbtongue stared up at the inn's name as the other Goblins walked in.

“You’re here!”

The instant they stepped through, a voice shouted. The Redfang warriors flinched and braced themselves, but all they saw was a girl. *The* girl. And she was smiling at them.

True, it wasn’t a great smile. It was tinged with nerves and a bit of fear, a bit of uncertainty, but it *was* still a smile. The Redfang warriors were too afraid to smile back.

“Come on in, don’t be shy. Sit. Here’s a table—sit down. I’m just going to get—Lyonette!”

The Goblins jumped as the young woman ran through a door behind a counter. They looked at the table and hesitantly pulled at the chairs. Chairs were another odd thing, but the five Hobgoblins perched on them tentatively. Rabbiteater’s ears kept twitching, and he turned his head sharply a moment before the Human girl rushed back into the room.

“Here. I have this—I know you need it.”

She had an armful of potions. The young woman carefully approached the table and the Goblins just as carefully leaned back. She hesitated and then dumped them onto the table. Headscratcher caught one before it could roll off and onto the floor.

“Thanks—”

The young woman froze at the same time the Goblin did. He’d reflexively started to hand the potion back to her, and she’d unconsciously

begun to take it. It was a universal experience, and they stared into each other's eyes for a moment before breaking away.

“You keep it. It's for you. For your injuries.”

The young woman backed away as Headscratcher lowered his hand. She pointed to his arm. He started, and then glanced at the crimson bandage he'd tied to his arm. The other Redfang warriors blinked too, and then recalled.

Yes, their injuries. Some were quite terrible. Headscratcher might lose that arm to infection or never regain its mobility, such was the damage. Badarrow had bites that went down to his bones on his legs, and the other Goblins were just as injured. And the potions were—

Healing potions? They had to be, but for them? The Goblins stared at the young woman, expecting, suspecting a trap. They eyed the bottles on the table.

Remembering the ones that had exploded earlier, the Goblins were hesitant, but then they recognized the liquids within. Most Goblins couldn't read, so they identified potion types by their appearance. And these *looked* like healing potions.

But who would give healing potions to a Goblin? That was what made the Goblins sure it had to be a trick. Not that they suspected the young woman of tricking them, but—

Logic warred with the evidence before their eyes. It was Numbtongue who moved first. He picked up a vial and squinted at the tiny label on it. After a moment he nodded and the others immediately uncorked the vials and bottles and poured them on their injuries. Then they received another surprise.

The healing potions were high quality. Headscratcher gaped as the chunk of flesh missing from his arm regrew over the course of a minute. This was *good* stuff! He looked at the young woman. She smiled hesitantly at him.

“Good? Use more if you need to.”

Mind boggling. The Goblins treated their wounds and then hesitantly recorked the bottles and pushed them together on the table. They felt guilty, as if they’d used too much, and eyed the diminished potion levels in the bottles uncertainly.

“You’re done? Cool. Let’s—why don’t I sit? I’ll sit here and we can... talk.”

So saying, the young woman scooted a chair out from another table and sat facing the Goblins. They looked at her. She looked back. The silence was unbearable.

“I am Erin. Erin Solstice. I’m an [Innkeeper].”

The Goblins stared at Erin. She coughed.

“Um. I know I said thanks, but thanks again. You saved me. I don’t know where those evil goats came from, but you were just in time. And I know your friend died...I’m sorry. And I’m also sorry that Bird shot at you. He’s the Antinium. The one on the tower.”

Silence. Erin shuffled her feet. The Goblins wondered if they should say something. And if so, what? They looked at Numbtongue. He shrugged.

“Are you with the—the Goblin Lord?”

Every head snapped back to Erin. She leaned back a bit and raised her hands.

“Not that I’m angry if you are. It’s just—I hear he’s not a great guy. But if you think he is, that’s fine! I’m not judging. But I just uh—”

All five Redfang warriors shook their heads at the same time. Erin looked relieved.

“Really? That’s great! You know, I thought he was a jerk, especially when his soldiers shot arrows at my inn, but I was thinking, here’s a bunch of Goblins and his army was just here, so...ahem.”

She broke off, and Headscratcher looked at the others. He raised a hand and crooked it towards her, tilting his head and baring his fangs. It was a quick statement, but he’d conveyed a general surprise that *any* building would have been left standing after the Goblin Lord had passed by. Shorthilt’s raised eyebrow and glance at one window told the others that his personal opinion was that this building had to be enchanted in some way.

The Human got none of this. She was fidgeting, glancing around, muttering under her breath. She looked at them and all five Goblins snapped back to attention.

“Okay. This might be weird, but...do you know a Goblin named Rags?”

Four jaws dropped. Badarrow’s eyes narrowed. Erin glanced from face to face. Her eyes widened. Rabbiteater nodded fractionally.

“You *do*?”

The Redfang warriors glanced at each other. How did she know *Rags*, let alone by name? Erin was bombarding them with questions while Badarrow kicked Rabbiteater under the table. He nodded to Erin, and then twirled his finger around, indicating the room as a whole.

The other Redfang warriors followed his gaze. They stared at the Human girl, looked around the inn, *her* inn, and put the pieces together at

last. The five Hobgoblins shuffled their feet and exchanged awkward glances.

This was so *embarrassing*.

Of course, Erin had no idea what they were thinking. She only saw their postures.

“Wait, what’s wrong? It’s not Rags, is it? Is she okay? I haven’t seen her in a long time—is she mad at me? Or...?”

Again, the Goblins shook their heads. How could they explain the inter-Goblin politics that had seen Rags absorb every tribe in the area to repel the Goblin Lord? Erin stared at them.

“Do you know where she is?”

They shook their heads. She hesitated.

“Okay. But is she well?”

They shrugged. Erin had to think.

“Do you...where are you going? Do you know where you’re going?”

They shook their heads again. Erin looked from face to face. Each Redfang warrior met her eyes, and then looked away. It was just a moment, but somehow, each felt like she’d seen a bit of the pain and despair they carried with them. Just for a moment.

“Okay. Okay...um...”

She wavered. As she did, Rabbiteater’s belly rumbled. Everyone stared at him. Erin shot to her feet. Rabbiteater nearly tumbled out of his chair.

“I’m so sorry! I totally forgot. I promised you food, right? Wait right here!”

She dashed into the kitchen. The other Goblins exchanged a look of wild surprise. Food? They'd buried a lot of the Eater Goat meat in the snow just in case, and they were hungry. But after the potions, they had to wonder. Would she actually feed them? Actually? With—with *forks* and the fancy tools Garen had told them all about?

Would there be anything to drink?

They heard banging in the kitchen, and Erin's raised voice, arguing with someone else. The Goblins stared at the kitchen anxiously. All but one.

There was a blackboard with words written on it in chalk hanging from a ledge above the bar's counter. It was a menu, although it had only been written once and never updated. Most people ignored it, but one of the Redfang warriors had spotted it.

Numbtongue studied the words written on the menu written above the bar's counter. He nudged Shorthilt, grunted and pointed. Shorthilt stared blankly at the letters. He shrugged. Numbtongue sighed. He carefully studied the words written on the menu until Erin came back.

"Here! Food, as promised!"

She had a huge platter and five plates awkwardly stacked on them. They were thick, filled with heaping mounds of spaghetti pasta, and covered with little black things. The other Goblins had no idea what the black things were. They were squishy, and looked edible, and that was good enough. Rabbiteater reached for one of the plates as Erin carefully placed it in front of him, but Numbtongue caught his hand. He shook his head and the other Redfang warriors, seeing the motion, froze.

"What's wrong?"

Erin looked at them, concerned. Numbtongue hesitated. He sucked in his lips, and then scowled. He hated doing this. Reluctantly he opened his

mouth and pointed to the plates and black things on them.

“Acid flies? Blue...fruit?”

Everyone stared at him. Erin’s jaw dropped. She stammered.

“How did—buh—I mean, I don’t have any acid flies. Those are olives! They’re healthy, I swear—I didn’t know they existed, but—this is spaghetti and olives! It’s uh—I’m out of blue juice too. Did you—can I get you something—wait, I have more!”

She rushed into the kitchen. The other Goblins stared at the olives. Badarrow picked one up and sniffed at it with deep suspicion. Rabbiteater gave in to his stomach and popped one into his mouth. He chewed, brightened, and began to shovel spaghetti into his mouth. The other Goblins looked at him, and then seized spaghetti in both claws.

Erin came back to find the Goblins shoveling spaghetti down their throats with incredible speed. If not delicacy. Watching Shorthilt tilt a plate back and slide all the spaghetti into his waiting mouth was an education in itself. The amazing bit was that not a single speck of spaghetti or olive was dropped. The Goblins cleaned their plates.

Slowly, the Human girl approached and the Goblins stopped eating. They stared at the mugs in her hands. Erin smiled and weakly raised the mugs filled with ale.

“I’ve uh, got drinks! Does anyone want a second helping?”

Erin had watched eating competitions on television when she was younger. It was a thing. She hadn’t exactly *liked* seeing someone wolf down

over forty hotdogs in one sitting, but she had to admire the speed at which it was done.

However, one of the things Erin had objected to was that in a food eating competition, none of the contestants ever seemed like they *liked* eating the food. It was about getting as much food as possible inside them as they could, not savoring the food.

By contrast, the Goblins sitting in the common room of her inn were a joy to watch eating. Because they clearly loved every bite. Oh, they still ate like starving wolverines, but every now and then one would pause and close his eyes while chewing, or make a grunting sound that expressed pure satisfaction.

Erin got to see only a bit of this, because she was rushing into the kitchen and out of it every few seconds. The Goblins didn't stop with the spaghetti, or the meatloaf, or the lasagna, pizza, or even the steak! They ate and ate, and *ate!*

Erin kept going into the kitchen and coming back with more pre-made dishes and watched them disappear. The Hobgoblins ate as if they were starving, which they must have been. They didn't *look* that scrawny, but Erin realized that if she compared them to the Hobgoblin she'd met before—the one who'd come in with Rags that one time—they were definitely a lot thinner.

She was worried they'd puke or their stomachs would get full, but the Goblins seemed to be able to digest the food as quickly as they ate. Their thin bellies inflated very slowly. As Erin grabbed a whole fried chicken seasoned with hot peppers, she decided she had to take a break. She turned to the Drake who was shakily cleaning dishes.

"Drassi, I need you to take over. Take this chicken out to the Goblins, will you?"

“*What?*”

The Drake jumped. Her pale scales grew paler and she raised her clawed hands.

“Erin, I can’t. I can’t even—I don’t know how you can have them here! *Here!* At least have Bird come downstairs with his bow! We should be calling the Watch, or, or—I can’t do it.”

Erin shook her head.

“Just serve them, okay Drassi? They won’t be dangerous and Bird is right there! Lyonette’s upstairs with Mrsha—I need to make more food or we’ll run out!”

“But—but—”

“Go out. Like this...hi guys! This is Drassi. She’s going to put the chicken down on the table. I said *down on the table*, Drassi—okay, why don’t you put it on *this* table?”

Erin managed to get Drassi to put the chicken down on the table and get her back into the kitchen. Drassi was trembling so hard she’d nearly dropped the whole thing. Erin had a suspicion that if she had, the Goblins would have picked it off the floor or just sat down and eaten it there.

“Okay, was that so hard?”

“*Yes!*”

Drassi glared at her. Erin sighed.

“But you did it. Just put the food on another table, okay? I’ve got to make more food. Uh...where’s the butter? And sprouts? They could probably use some greens with all the heavy food they’ve been eating.”

She began to fry greens, put together a soup, and start a few loaves of bread all at once. Drassi took out a few more dishes very reluctantly, but reported the Hobgoblins did indeed seem to be slowing now. Erin let her finish putting all the food onto platters for later and tending to the soup—and mountains of finished dishes, and walked out into the room.

Five pairs of eyes instantly focused on her. Erin froze, and then waved. One of the five Goblins waved back. The others just watched her.

Drassi's fear was understandable, Erin felt. Each time she moved, the Goblins all stared at her. Erin waved at them and pointed.

“I'm just going upstairs. Okay?”

They didn't reply, but watched her as she climbed the stairs. Erin found Lyonette and Mrsha's room and hesitated before knocking on the door.

“Lyonette? Mrsha? Are you two okay?”

“Erin?”

She heard a lock turn and then the door opened. Lyonette opened the door a crack.

“Come in.”

Erin edged into the room and saw that Lyonette was sitting on her bed with Apista and Mrsha. The bee was crawling onto her pillow and Mrsha was shivering in Lyonette's arms.

“Is Mrsha okay?”

“I think so. She's not that afraid any longer, are you Mrsha? She's just—she can smell the Goblins downstairs, Erin.”

Lyonette didn't quite look at Erin as she ran a soothing hand over Mrsha's back. The Gnoll flinched when she heard the word ‘Goblin’. Erin

paused.

“Right.”

Mrsha had her past with Goblins. Erin had almost forgotten that. She sat by the bed. Mrsha looked at her. Erin offered her a hand and the Gnoll licked it.

“It’s okay, Mrsha. They’re not bad, I promise.”

“You’re sure?”

Lyonette spoke for the both of them. Erin hesitated. She looked at Lyonette. She realized she’d made a mistake. She’d assumed Lyonette would understand the Goblins being here, but the other girl was clearly as upset as Mrsha was. Erin paused, stroking Mrsha’s head.

“You never really knew Rags, did you?”

“I remember seeing her and screaming. But I didn’t, no. I’m sorry.”

“Right. And she was only here...look Lyonette, I know you’re nervous. Drassi definitely is. But these Goblins aren’t dangerous. I’d feel it with my [Dangersense] if they were. And they helped us.”

Lyonette nodded, but she didn’t look convinced. She stared at the floorboards, and then Apista as the bee crawled up a wall. She took a breath.

“I know your friend—Rags—was a guest here. But Erin, I have to say it. These aren’t normal Goblins. They’re *Hobs*. They lead other Goblins and they’re very, very dangerous. One Hob is a match for most Silver-rank adventurers. More than a match, sometimes.”

“I get that. But Lyonette, they saved us. They saved me, and they didn’t have to.”

“I know. I saw. They saved you from the goats, but they also shot Bird. I was the one who heard him fall. Erin, he would have died.”

Erin nodded. Her hand clenched. Bird was upstairs. He had a small room on the third floor and she’d ordered him to rest after his near-death experience.

“I know. But it was self-defense. And I owed them something. Look, I’ll feed them for now and we’ll see what happens, okay?”

“You’re the boss.”

That was a bad answer, and Lyonette clearly wasn’t happy about it, but it would have to do. Erin nodded, relieved. Then she bent down to Mrsha.

“I know they’re—I know they’re Goblins, okay Mrsha, honey? But they’re not like the other ones, I promise. They won’t hurt you.”

The Gnoll was still shaking, but she raised her head as Erin spoke to her. Erin was prepared for tears or fear, but that wasn’t what was in the Gnoll cub’s gaze. Her eyes blazed. They narrowed as Mrsha stared at Erin. There was anger there. Anger and deep reproach.

She had no words. But Mrsha made her opinion clear. Erin froze.

“Mrsha? They’re going to stay a bit longer. But they won’t come upstairs. Got it? If they cause any trouble, they’re gone. I promise. Just wait here, okay? I’ll get Drassi to come up with food—”

For once the promise of food didn’t satisfy Mrsha. The Gnoll swiped at Erin’s hand and she stared at Erin until the young woman left the room. Erin walked down the stairs and took a deep breath. Then she groaned.

“Oh no. What now?”

Someone had entered the common room ahead of her. An Antinium was holding a bow, and the room had frozen. Drassi was standing, shaking,

mugs in hand, and the Goblin warriors had frozen, half of them about to leap out of their seats.

“Bird!”

Erin ran down the stairs. The Antinium turned his head, but his arms kept the bow trained on the Goblins.

“Miss Erin, they were attempting to leave.”

“What? Leave?”

Erin looked at the Goblins. They hesitated. One pointed towards the doors.

“You want to go? Why?”

Again, hesitation. The Goblin pointed down. Everyone stared at his crotch. Erin’s face went slack until she realized what he meant.

“Pee? You want to—Bird, he just wants to go to the bathroom!”

“Oh. That was the reason I descended as well.”

The Antinium slowly lowered the bow. The Goblins relaxed just as slowly. Erin strode between them, raising her hands, trying to play peacemaker again.

“Let’s all calm down. We don’t want any accidents...especially the yellow kind. There’s outhouses for everyone. The bathroom’s right outside. Here, I can show you—”

That seemed to be unnecessary. The Goblin shook his head as he walked towards the door. He put a hand on the handle and pulled it open. The door revealed a startled Jelaqua Ivirith, her hand raised to push at the door. She stared at the Goblin, and her eyes went wide. The Goblin stared back.

Jelaqua backed up. Her face was always dead white, but now she seemed to be stunned. Horrified. She opened her mouth and stared at the Hobgoblin standing in front of her.

“Garen?”

The Goblin stared back. He recognized the word, Erin saw. He opened his mouth.

“Redfang?”

A giant hand reached past Jelaqua. Moore grabbed the Goblin and *threw* him across the room. The Hobgoblin crashed into a wall. Jelaqua sprinted into the room as the other Hobgoblins shot to their feet.

The Goblin who’d been thrown struggled upright. He swung wildly at Jelaqua—she grabbed one arm and then brought his head down to meet her knee. The Hobgoblin stumbled, and she knocked him flat with one punch. Jelaqua stood over the downed Hobgoblin and looked around. Then she looked at the unconscious Goblin at her feet.

“Oh. It’s not Garen. I was worried there for a second.”

The other Hobgoblins leapt over the table at her, roaring. One *jerked* as Seborn clotheslined him in midair and slung him to the ground. The Drowned Man leapt on the Hobgoblin and started beating him down with his fists.

“Stop, *stop!*”

Erin shouted, but Moore’s staff was already spinning. He flattened one Hob, and kicked the other. Jelaqua’s gauntleted fists flashed and the final Hobgoblin jerked back, stumbling from her punch. He fainted and jabbed at her; the Selphid let both punches meet her armor and hit him in the gut and chest with solid, heavy blows that made the Goblin stumble.

“Enough!”

Erin’s shout this time was backed up by more than just sound. The air in the inn *cracked* and the floor rumbled. The Halfseekers paused, eyes wide, and the two Goblins still on their feet halted as well.

Slowly, very slowly, Erin turned to look around the room. Jelaqua’s eyes flicked to the Hobgoblins, to Drassi poking her head out of the kitchen, and Bird who opened the door and paused when he saw the chaos. She looked at Erin and groaned.

“Please tell me this isn’t what it looks like.”

The other two Halfseekers looked around. Moore shook his head. Seborn got up slowly.

“Miss Solstice, I believe we’re owed an explanation.”

Erin looked from face to face and tried to smile weakly. The normally jovial Halfseekers didn’t return the smiles. Right. They didn’t like Goblins either. She gestured to the tables.

“Why don’t we all sit. Does—does anyone want a drink?”

The drinks did help, but barely. The Goblins sat in a corner of the room, their injuries healed once again with Erin’s potions. Jelaqua shook her head grimly as Erin finished the story.

“And so you invited them in. Why am I not surprised?”

“It’s just—they saved my life, Jelaqua.”

Erin spread her hands helplessly. Jelaqua turned and glared at the Goblins. They flinched. There was a clear distribution of power there, and they could tell they were on the losing end of it. The other two Halfseekers looked just as grim.

“We like all kinds of species Erin, but our group has its problems with Goblins. You do know we *lost* half our members to one?”

Jelaqua’s statement made the other Goblins sit up at their table. Moore’s eyes were shadowed as he watched them. Seborn’s gaze could have fried the egg in front of him. Erin waved her hands, trying to defuse the situation.

“I know, I know! But these are good Goblins, guys! Just give me a moment. They might not be here long. I’m just feeding them!”

“Right. Well, you’d better explain that to the others.”

Jelaqua glanced towards the door. Erin looked as well.

“What others?”

“Your usual crowds. Who else? I saw the Horns finishing up their request at the Adventurer’s Guild a while back. They’ll be here soon too, and a bunch of people from Liscor. You’d better have a good explanation ready for them, too.”

“Oh no. Wait here. Drassi! Go to Celum and make sure no one comes through! Jelaqua, Goblins—stay here!”

Erin ran for the door. She threw it open and saw the Horns of Hammerad and a number of other people trudging towards her inn through the snow. Her dinner crowd, as usual. Erin raced down the hill towards them.

“We’re closed! Go away! Shoo!”

The people heading towards her inn hesitated as Erin ran towards them. She shouted, waved her arms. Ceria frowned as Erin shouted at the others.

“Erin? What’s going on? What do you mean you’re closed?”

“Does this mean there is, in fact, no *food*?”

Pisces peered at Erin, looking concerned. She grinned desperately.

“That’s right! No food! We have a—a thing going on. A thing with the food! I’m sorry, but you’ll have to come back later! Not you, though.”

She grabbed Pisces as he turned around and dragged him back. The other Horns of Hammerad clustered around Erin as she whispered to them.

“There’s a minor thing in the inn, okay? We’ll all go up and nobody scream, okay?”

“Goblin!”

Every head turned. A Drake who’d approached the inn from a different spot on the hill backed out of the door, scales pale. He turned to them and ran down the hill, waving his arms and screaming.

“Hobs! There’s five Hobgoblins in there! It’s an invasion! Run for your lives!”

Erin groaned. She saw her guests turn and began fleeing towards Liscor’s gates. Alerted by the commotion, the guards on the walls began shouting down at the people below. In moments, horns were blowing.

Ceria looked at Erin. Yvlon, Ksmvr, and Pisces did likewise. Slowly, Erin turned and grinned weakly at them. Ceria crossed her arms.

“Erin. What have you done?”

“Human!”

Erin flinched as the door to her inn slammed open. The five Redfang warriors would have jumped to their feet, but the two adventurer teams kept them seated. They tensed as a group of heavily-armed guardsmen led by Zevara herself stormed into the room. The Drake Watch Captain halted when she saw the Hobgoblins, and then rounded on Erin.

“I didn’t believe it when I heard it. I thought even a Human, even *you* wouldn’t be stupid enough for this. Harboring *five* Hobgoblins? Now? While the Goblin Lord is marching on our cities? Have you lost your *mind?*”

“I can explain!”

Erin strode forwards quickly and put herself between Zevara and the Goblins. She saw Relc standing behind Zevara with a group of Drakes in full plate armor. He and the other guardsmen were ready for a fight. But it couldn’t come to that.

“Speak quickly, Human.”

Zevara lashed her tail as she stared at the Hobgoblins. Her sword was half out of its sheath, and the [Guardsmen] behind her looked ready to fight. Relc’s eyes smoldered as he stared at the Goblins. They were tense, but they waited for Erin to speak.

She explained as fast as she could. Zevara was incredulous.

“You were attacked by *goats?*”

“Eater Goats, Captain. They have to be. Those buggers are nasty. If there’s a herd coming down from the High Passes—”

One of the guardsmen murmured to Zevara. She turned to Erin.

“We’ll inspect the bodies. But if these Hobs fought them, so what? Monsters fight monsters.”

“But they did it to save the village! I’m sure of it! They attacked the goats when they were about to jump over the walls! Look, Captain, I know they’re Goblins, but remember Rags?”

Behind Zevara, Relc twitched. Zevara glanced at him, then at Erin.

“I remember a group of Goblins starting to raid the roads around Liscor before they vanished. If that’s your argument—”

“These Goblins aren’t a danger! I promise!”

“Hah! And I’m supposed to let five Hobgoblins sit here while—”

“It’s *five* Goblins.”

“Five *Hobs*! Do you understand how dangerous that is? A Silver-rank team wouldn’t be a match for them! And why are they without a tribe? They could be spies, saboteurs—”

“Why did they sit in my inn and eat food for the last two hours, then?”

Zevara hesitated. She eyed the Goblins. One waved at her. Another raised his middle finger.

“It could be a Goblin ploy—”

“Oh come on. Really?”

Some of the guardsmen shifted behind Erin. One murmured.

“She has a point, Captain. That would be stupid, even for a Goblin—”

“They might have heard there’s a softhearted Human with a fondness for Goblins around here. Maybe they lured the Eater Goats here themselves. I

don't know, but I'm not having them here! And you, why would you think this is a good idea?"

The Drake Watch Captain glared at Erin. She glared back.

"Haven't you seen the sign outside my inn? Didn't you read what it says? It says, 'no killing Goblins'!"

Zevara paused.

"That's not—"

Erin glared at her. She rounded on the other Drakes and Gnolls in the Watch, raising her voice.

"Did you think that was a joke? That I wasn't serious? I am. Unless the Goblin is attacking me or other people, or stealing or—or being a jerk, I won't let you harm them."

Zevara's eyes narrowed dangerously.

"This is Watch business, Human. You may not be in Liscor, but you're close enough to fall under our jurisdiction."

"So what, you'll kill them right here and now because you think they might be a threat?"

The Drake hesitated. She eyed the Goblins. They were watching her. At last, she nodded.

"That was our intent."

All five Redfang warriors shifted at once. The Watch did likewise. Zevara held up a hand.

"We won't have a fight here. I'd rather force these Goblins to leave the area than risk any deaths."

Slowly, the Redfang Goblins relaxed their grips on their weapons. But Erin was the one who objected this time.

“You can’t.”

“What?”

“They’re starving. Can’t you see?”

She pointed at the Goblins. The Redfang warriors glanced at her in astonishment. Erin spread her hands.

“They were hungry when they came in, and I think they’re on the run. They aren’t allied with the Goblin Lord—I think they’re part of Rags’ tribe. Look, Captain Zevara, why can’t I let them stay in my inn for a day or two?”

Everyone was gaping at her. Zevara shook her head.

“You really are as crazy as Relc says. I won’t allow it.”

“Well, I won’t let you lay a hand on these Goblins! Give me a day or two and I’ll let them go—maybe out of Celum. But no one’s hurting them here.”

Zevara stared incredulously at Erin.

“And what will you do if we decide to move them? Stop us? By yourself?”

She glanced around the inn. Both the Halfseekers and the Horns of Hammerad were present, but they didn’t seem inclined to stand up for Erin the same way as they had before. Erin nodded.

“If I have to.”

Someone in the group of guards people laughed. Zevara stared at Erin.

“Stand aside. We’re removing the Goblins.”

Erin’s eyes narrowed.

“Try it.”

For a heart-thundering second, Zevara’s hand tightened on her sword’s hilt and every warrior in the room tensed. Then the door opened. Half a dozen swords cleared their sheaths, but the figure standing in the doorway made everyone hesitate.

“Enough. Watch Captain Zevara, stand down.”

Zel Shivertail stood in the doorway. He glanced around, pinning the Redfang warriors with a glance. The Drakes backed up and he strode forwards to speak with Zevara. The two Drakes bent their heads. Erin couldn’t hear anything, but she saw Zevara’s tail lashing and caught a few words.

“—on my authority—can’t be s—quite. The situation—won’t allow—follow orders.”

At last, Zevara turned. She looked like she was ready to blast Erin with flames, but she held back. She clenched her claws into fists and glared pure murder at the Goblins.

“If they hurt anyone, it’s on your head, Human!”

She whirled and stormed out of the room. Slowly, the guardsmen followed her. In the newfound stillness, Zel Shivertail looked at Erin. He sighed.

“A word, Miss Solstice?”

They stood outside and spoke in the cold.

“Thank you for helping me. I don’t know what would have happened if you hadn’t.”

Zel inclined his head slightly. He glanced through a window into the inn, where the Redfang Goblins were still sitting, tense, watched by both adventurer groups.

“Truthfully, I don’t know if I should have. Goblins are dangerous, Miss Solstice.”

“I know that. But I think these ones are good. Why *did* you help me, by the way?”

Zel grimaced.

“Call it instinct. Not mine. Yours. You picked out Regrika Blackpaw and her associate’s treachery. If you can do that, perhaps you’re right about these Goblins. But truthfully, I have ulterior motives.”

“Which are?”

Erin studied Zel, but he didn’t meet her gaze.

“I’m sorry. But I can’t say. Regardless, I managed to convince Watch Captain Zevara to back down. However, if those Goblins cause any kind of disturbance—”

“I’ll make sure they won’t. And they won’t necessarily stay here. I just—I couldn’t leave them alone, you know?”

Erin shrugged helplessly. The Drake [General] eyed her and sighed.

“No, you really couldn’t, could you? Well, I will let you handle this at your discretion—however many misgivings I have. But if you...no. I’m

afraid, though, that if you do intend to shelter the Goblins, I won't be staying at the inn."

"Why?"

Erin stared at him. Zel Shivertail paused.

"I fought Goblins back in the Second Antinium war, and countless times before and since. They're monsters to me, I'm afraid. I wouldn't be able to sleep under the same roof as them. I'm sorry. I've seen what they can do, and while I can trust your word...I'm sorry."

He looked at Erin. She hesitated, and then nodded slowly.

"I get it. But I think...I think I will offer them a place to stay for now. I don't think they have anywhere to go. And I...want to know about Rags."

Zel nodded.

"In that case, I'll move out before tonight. I wish you luck, Miss Solstice."

He turned. Erin called out behind him.

"Why *did* you do it? Stand up for me? And why were you sure I'd give them a place to stay?"

Zel looked back.

"You're kind to strangers, Erin Solstice. That's all. And that's not a bad thing. If you can prove some Goblins are worth living, well, who am I to stop you?"

Then he walked into the inn. After a second, Erin followed him.

“Do you...have names?”

Erin sat with the Redfang Goblins. They stared at her, and glanced behind her. Zel Shivertail was talking quietly with Lyonette, who was upset with Erin, and he was talking to Mrsha, who was clinging to his leg. Sitting around the room were the Horns of Hammerad and the Halfseekers, who were both watching them as well.

Erin tried to ignore all of them. She focused on the Goblin ahead of her.

“I’m Erin. But you know that. Do you have names?”

They hesitated. The Goblins looked at each other, and shrugged. They weren’t proper names, not like Rags had. But they were something. Erin looked at Headscratcher and pointed to him.

“Okay, what’s yours?”

He scratched his head. She waited. The Goblin looked at her and scratched his head again.

“You don’t know?”

He shook his head and then pointed to it. He slowly and deliberately scratched his head.

“Headscratching?”

Pisces coughed. He cleared his throat as Erin looked at him.

“I believe, Miss Solstice, that the answer is far simpler. That is his name. And rather than Headscratching, I believe you would call him... Headscratcher?”

Headscratcher nodded in relief. Erin stared at him.

“What, really?”

The skepticism in her voice hurt more than any ridicule. Headscratcher drooped and Erin tried to reassure him.

“No, no, it’s a great name! I’m just surprised. You’re Headscratcher. That’s cool. And uh, what about you?”

She pointed at Shorthilt. The other Goblin began to pantomime as well. Erin’s brows furrowed as she tried to work his name out.

“Short. Right. I got that. Short...short...sword? No? Short hilt? Shorthilt? That’s your name?”

He gave her a short nod and stared challengingly at her. Erin sucked in her lips.

“Right. It’s uh, a good name! Very original. I think.”

Slowly, she went around the table, getting each name from each Goblin. Rabbiteater and Numbtongue were hardest to figure out, especially because Erin had neither rabbits nor numbing agents in her inn. But they got there.

“It’s nice to meet you all. Headscratcher, Shorthilt, Badapple—sorry, sorry! Badarrow, Rabbiteater, and Numbtongue, right?”

They all nodded. All four Goblins had repeatedly elbowed Numbtongue throughout the conversation, but he’d refused to open his mouth. Now Erin smiled at them. Goblin hearts did odd things in their chests and more than one Goblin poked at his heart experimentally.

“Good to meet you all. Sorry about everything earlier. Let’s do this properly. I’m Erin, this is Ceria, Pisces, Ksmvr, Yvlon—Drassi’s hiding in the kitchen. She’s the Drake. Lyonette and Mrsha are upstairs...Mrsha’s the cute little Gnoll. And uh, this is Jelaqua—”

The Selphid leaned over her table. She wasn’t smiling.

“Where is Garen Redfang? How do you know him?”

The Redfang warriors looked at her. Her eyes were fixed on them. Slowly, Headscratcher raised one finger. He pointed at himself and the others, spoke a word.

“Redfang.”

Erin stared blankly at Jelaqua. The Selphid frowned. Someone else spoke up.

“They must be his tribe.”

The Halfseekers turned and looked at Yvlon. The armored woman cleared her throat as everyone stared at her.

“I know a bit about them. I don’t know about Garen Redfang himself, but the Redfang tribe...they’re a notorious Goblin tribe around here. They’ve been active for years and no one’s managed to defeat them or find their lair. They live in the High Passes.”

Seborn shifted in his seat. His gaze hadn’t shifted from the Goblins since he’d sat down.

“We heard about that. What else do you know?”

Yvlon conferred with Ceria for a moment.

“They’re supposed to be the most dangerous Goblin tribe around the High Passes. The best at fighting—some of them ride Carn Wolves, and they’re rated as a threat that no single Gold-rank team should try to handle alone. By all accounts, they’ve done away with several Gold-rank teams and quite a lot of Silver-rank teams over the years.”

The other Redfang warriors looked proud. Headscratcher kicked them under the table and they paused, and then shuffled their feet. Jelaqua shook her head.

“That’s what we heard. But I only care about Garen Redfang. Your leader. Where is he?”

She looked at Headscratcher. He and the others all shook their heads and shrugged at the same time. Jelaqua made a sound of disgust and rose to her feet.

“Great. I can’t sit here. Moore, come on. Seborn, you stay in case something happens.”

She stomped out of the inn. Erin watched her go. Then she looked at the Goblins.

Now then. Now, after all the drama...she still didn’t know what to do with them. Part of her wanted to go tell Zel that they were leaving and he could stay. The rest of her knew that she’d made up her mind as soon as she’d seen them.

Goblins. Hobgoblins. Did it matter? The five who sat at the table warily eying her and the others in the room were like Rags and unlike her in so many ways. They were bigger, all male, and clearly trained warriors, but their eyes were the same. There was the same hurt there, the same curiosity when they stared at her magical chessboard or saw something new.

And they had seen too much. She remembered seeing their wounds and they had too many scars. They had been starving. Their stomachs were bulging, but they still looked like they could eat.

And one more thing made Erin sure. A memory. That last time she had seen Rags, she had turned her away. This time...Erin closed her eyes. She took a breath, and looked at them.

“I know a lot of people came by and threatened you. However, you all don’t seem to know where you’re going, am I right?”

The Redfang warriors shuffled their feet. Shorthilt nodded. Badarrow kicked him under the table. Erin smiled for a second.

“In that case...stay, okay? No one’s going to kill you. Not while I’m here. Stay. If you’re looking for Rags, well—you can stay here for a while at least. You need to eat, and sleep. I promise you, if you stay, you’ll be safe.”

The Goblins looked at her incredulously. So did the Horns of Hammerad, Lyonette, Drassi, and everyone else in the room. Zel just sighed and hefted his pack onto his back. Erin hesitated. She looked into Headscratcher’s eyes.

Was she making a mistake? Yes. No one would come to an inn with Goblins. No one. The door to Celum had opened twice despite Octavia’s attempts and the people had fled screaming upon seeing the Goblins. Zevara was angry, Relc was angry—Erin had no idea if Klbkch and the Antinium would be too. This was not smart. And yet—

A Goblin’s tears. She looked into Headscratcher’s eyes and remembered. Crying for their friend. Who’d died to help protect her. Without thanks, without a grave. Without a word spoken.

“Stay.”

She reached out and offered her hand. The Goblins stared at her. Slowly, Headscratcher raised his hand. He raised it and slowly extended it. His palm was callused, his grip as tentative as a feather. His blood pulsed beneath his skin, and he looked Erin in the eye.

She smiled. And then she turned and looked around the room.

“Who else is staying?”

It might be no one. Lyonette was willing to stay, but Mrsha might have to go to the city, in which case Lyonette would go. Erin wanted to try a single night at the inn, but she wasn't sure. As for the Horns of Hammerad, they had a quiet discussion in a corner. Ceria was very upset, which in turn made Erin upset.

"Look, just be cool, okay? They can stay in the—in the basement for tonight. Okay?"

"Erin! We sleep in the basement! And these are *Hobs*! I get Rags, I really do, but—"

"Ceria. It's not a discussion. I'm sorry, but if you really can't deal with them you'll have to go somewhere else. But look—they'll be in the basement but you *won't*."

"What do you mean?"

Ceria frowned. Erin smiled weakly at her.

"I finished upgrading my inn, remember? And I have all those new rooms—I was going to offer them to you anyways. You'll get rooms on the second floor if you stay. Okay?"

The half-Elf looked at Erin uncertainly, and exchanged a glance with Yvlon. Beside her, Pisces' eyes lit up. He nudged Ceria in the side.

"Take the offer, Springwalker."

"Oh come on. You can't be serious, Pisces—"

The half-Elf turned and glared at him. He glared back.

"I would live with a *Creler* in the basement if it meant a private room for myself, Springwalker. Five Goblins is a small price to pay for an upgrade."

“Plus, you’ll all get separate rooms! And mints on your pillows as soon as I learn how to make them! Please? Come on Ceria, you remember Rags. She was cool! These guys are cool too! Probably.”

Erin pleaded and begged, and in the end Ceria gave over, mainly because rooms at Erin’s inn were infinitely preferable to cramped rooms in Celum or Liscor, especially with the prices they might have to pay. That was one issue solved.

The other one was more serious. Erin had two new hires, and she suspected both objected to the Goblins in no uncertain terms. At least, she knew Drassi did. She hadn’t seen Ishkr for a while. He was still in mourning.

In any case, Ishkr was still missing, but Drassi was on the roster for tomorrow and the day after as well. Erin sat with her as the Goblins...did something in the basement.

“Honestly, Erin, I don’t know if I can. I—it’s not that I don’t like you or trust you, but having *monsters* under this roof—”

“I get it, Drassi, I do. And I know you’re upset, Jelaqua, Moore, Seborn. I wouldn’t blame you if you left, but please give this a chance?”

She was begging with the Halfseekers as well. They were hesitating for the same reasons as Ceria had. There weren’t many places that catered to Selphids and half-Giants both. Still, Jelaqua’s jaw was clenched and she kept glancing towards the trapdoor leading to the basement.

“Just tell us why, Erin. I get that they saved your life, but a meal’s thanks enough. So these Goblins are lost. So what? What makes them worth trusting?”

“I don’t think they’re monsters. I think they’re lost. They *look* lost, Jelaqua. And so...so sad. I couldn’t just tell them to wander off and get

killed by adventurers or monsters.”

“And you trust them? You trust them not to slit your throat in the night? Because they could. You’re in danger, and everyone in this inn. You might trust them, but...how sure are you? Are you willing to bet your life on this?”

The Selphid eyed Erin. Drassi looked at her as well. Erin bowed her head. Then she raised it.

“I am. I believe in people. I believe that Goblins are more than monsters. Because they act like people. They might act like monsters, but—don’t people say that about Selphids? To a Human like me, a Drake might be a monster. Or a Gnoll. But they have feelings. And so do the Goblins. They might not speak, but they *cry*. And I think that if you can cry, you’re a person.”

Erin clenched her hands on the table. Drassi looked at her, and then blew her nose—or rather, nose holes—noisily on a handkerchief. Jelaqua stared at her, and then looked at Moore and Seborn. Moore brushed at his eyes. The Selphid sighed. Seborn looked at his human hand and his crustacean side. All three Halfseekers had the same look, bordering on tears of their own in their eyes. They nodded. Jelaqua made an unhappy face.

“When you put it like that...how can we up and leave? We’ll stay too. Just in case you need us. But we won’t hang around with them, Erin. I just can’t.”

“I get that. I can serve you breakfast whenever, or make up a bag—thank you so much.”

Erin rose and grasped Jelaqua’s hands. The Selphid laughed and shook her head.

“Do you know how many people shudder when they hold my hands? Do you know how many people think Moore eats people? A chance. Dead gods, I guess I’ll try anything once.”

“Once upon a time, I remember you saying the same thing when a Hobgoblin wanted to join our group.”

Moore’s eyes were distant. Seborn nodded.

“We were betrayed once. But remember what Ukrina said? ‘If we do not give other species a chance, what hope is there for the rest of the world?’ Once more, Jelaqua.”

The Selphid turned to Erin and gave her a crooked smile.

“You heard them. Sentimentalists, that’s us. Okay, let’s do this.”

And that evening, Erin stood in her common room and felt a strange sensation creeping up on her. A familiar feeling.

Emptiness. Silence. Isolation.

Her inn, normally bustling, was deserted. Her upper floors were almost empty. Mrsha, happy Mrsha, refused to come downstairs. Drassi was hiding in the kitchens and the fire in the common room was low.

And yet, she didn’t feel terrible. Erin stood in the common room and felt a chill. She brushed her arms and realized only part of that was coming from the fire. She went over and fed it fuel, but the feeling persisted.

Rags. Goblins. A dying Goblin lying in her kitchen. The smell of burnt oil. Erin couldn’t give the feeling in her heart words, but perhaps. Perhaps what Zel, what Jelaqua said was true. Was she making a mistake or—

A foot *creaked* as it met a floorboard. Erin whirled, and saw a big shape hunched by the open trapdoor. A Goblin crouched, crimson eyes on her. Erin stepped away from the fire, heart pounding, and the figure was cast into relief.

Headscratcher crouched by the trapdoor, frozen in place. He stared at Erin. She stared back. He wasn't holding a weapon or anything. And he wasn't wearing anything. That was very apparent.

Her eyes travelled down. Headscratcher was *very* naked. Erin raised her voice.

“Drassi? Go into the city and buy some pants, would you? I think the Goblins need extra pairs. Their loincloths are, um, bloodstained.”

“What? *Pan*—”

Drassi poked her head out of the kitchen and stared before screaming. Headscratcher shuffled down the trapdoor, looking very embarrassed. Erin turned away and heard the trap door open and close. She hesitated, and then went into the kitchen to calm Drassi.

When that was over, Erin laughed to herself. Silly Goblins. For some reason that reassured her. If you could be silly, if you could be embarrassed, you weren't a monster, right? You were only a monster if people called you that.

Her eyes travelled back across her empty room. Yes, the word had spread. Now everyone in both cities knew. She had Goblins. Erin laughed. So what? They weren't evil, she was sure.

And this time, Erin swore, she'd treat them better. As Drassi hurried out of the inn, Erin found the sign that had been buried all winter in the snow. She eyed it, dug it out of the frozen ground after much swearing, and replanted it. Right in front of her inn, by the door. For the world to see.

“This is my inn. Mine.”

Erin spoke to the warming world, into the darkness. She rested a hand on the cold wood. Yes, this was who she was. What her inn was.

The Wandering Inn. It had one rule. No killing Goblins. Erin smiled to herself. Yes. This time she’d do it right. She’d be better. And show them—show everyone—there were some Goblins who weren’t evil.

She turned and froze. Headscratcher, Badarrow, and Shorthilt all froze as they crept through the snow. They were all naked, and all, apparently, in dire need of the outhouse. She stared, and then shouted.

“Put some pants on!”

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Day 72

In this world, the main method of transportation between settlements is with wagons. True, you could argue that Runners and magic play their own roles, but the price for such deliveries is usually out of reach for the common villager. They might be able to afford a letter in a bulk delivery or a trinket to send to a loved one or relative, but as regular, reliable transportation? Never.

Indeed, you could say that Runners are, by and large, more useful for their discretion and ability to deliver messages and items without fear of interception. The best Runners in the world deliver for [Lords] and [Kings], after all. Whereas magic trivializes the issue of sending letters between two [Mages]—but at a higher cost. Accordingly, sending a small package instantly from one spot to a point across the world is possible, but the cost is beyond prohibitive.

So wagons rule, at least for bulk deliveries. Or, at least, they would if bags of holding hadn't been invented. Give a Runner one of those and they can deliver goods faster and more reliably than a caravan. So extremely rich cities with powerful Runner's Guilds like Invril can actually out-muscle the local Merchant's Guild. But bags of holding are very expensive, so wagons rule in low-income areas with less substantial urban development.

The point I'm making with all of this is that wagons are important, so roads are important. Keeping a road maintained and free of monsters or bandits is crucial to a small town or village's survival. The problem is that the said bandits and monsters know it.

The Goblin raiding force hit the caravan of [Traders] just past dawn. They streamed out of a cave where they had been lurking for the last few hours or so and charged down the hill towards the wagons and armed guards. The Humans, lone Gnoll, and two half-Elves screamed and tried to form a circle with the wagons, but the Goblins were too quick.

The raiding force met the few caravan guards hard, killing two of the armed warriors in the first clash. Three Hobs led the lesser Goblins, smashing aside warriors. The [Traders] fought back with their guards, but they were outmatched. They hadn't brought enough guards for a long trip; they'd trusted to speed to get them from one town to another. They could make the journey in an hour or two. Less, with Skills.

But that window was all the time the Goblins needed. They only needed ten minutes, in fact. Away from any kind of large militia or the walls of a city, they could raid and be gone too quickly for pursuit. And the [Traders] could hardly afford Silver-rank teams to protect them, could they? And if they could...three Hobs were more than a match for a single team.

A flawless strategy. Or rather, it had been flawless until now. Because despite all their preparations, the way the Goblins had carefully snuck into the cave through a back entrance and their [Stalkers] had crept along the road, out of view, they had still been seen. And preparation was everything.

“Are we too late to save the caravan?”

I'm miles away from the stretch of road, too far away to see the desperate fighting among the wagons or the way the blood mixes with the mud and snow on the ground. Too far to see with my eyes, that is. But my [Emperor] senses can see the Goblins—thirty or so—pushing forwards, shouting wordlessly. And I can also sense the second force, not [Traders] or Goblins, approaching at speed out of the woods.

In the silence of my mind, I can see a figure racing ahead of the group, see him put a horn to his lips and blow. There is no sound in the vision in my head, but I can see the Goblins turning, reacting to the horn call. I smile. Hello, Goblins. Allow me to introduce myself.

I'm Laken. An [Emperor], ruler of Riverfarm, Protector of Durene's Cottage, and now sovereign lord of Windrest, Tunslaven, Kiquel, and the surrounding areas. Some call my territory the Unseen Empire, but I think that's a bit too arrogant. Anyways, I may be blind, but I saw you coming. And this is my army.

The Goblins brought thirty, so I sent sixty. Simple math and it's pretty much our entire force, so I don't feel worried about leaving people behind. Not that there's much danger; I can sense any threat coming and react accordingly. Like this. And my army has fought Goblins before.

This is how it goes down. The Goblins are still reacting, still turning to see the force of armed warriors on foot racing out of the woods, when Beniar's [Cavalry], [Riders], and lone [Cataphract] crash into them from the side. They actually take down one of the Hobs in the first clash; a lance straight through the armpit. I wince as I sit in Prost's house. Nasty.

The riders fight for a second and the Goblins, used to battle, turn on them, trying to swarm the riders off the mounts. But Beniar's already pulling back, circling for another charge. He's timed it well or Wiskeria has; the infantry crash into the other side of the Goblins in tight formation. Leading the charge is a tall half-Troll I watch with anxiety and pride alike.

Durene. She's still not wearing armor because none fits her, and her club's still made of wood, but her shield is better than the old door she used to use. She shouts a word as she leads the assault on the Goblins' rear. I sense her body begin to glow and Goblins shrinking back, shouting wordlessly.

Now, what would she be shouting? Probably the Skill. [Radiant Courage]! Durene's body is shining with light, but the glow doesn't bother the soldiers around her. They charge, shields raised, into the Goblins and reap the benefits of their enemy's sudden blindness. Durene smashes two Goblins with her club like a hammer. Her Skill is devastating in group fights like this, where she can blind her enemies while keeping her allies safe. Now Durene charges forwards at the closest Hob.

He's dangerous. This Hob has a battleaxe and he turns, the sharp blade dripping with blood, towards Durene. And he seems less affected by the light she emits. He lashes out with his axe and she raises her shield. I see Durene shouting again. Now her shield glows. The Goblins and Hob around Durene stumble back as a wall blocks them from swarming my beloved [Paladin]. Durene grits her teeth. I see her plant her feet in the mud, raise her shield and *shove*. Goblins go flying through the air and the Hob stumbles back.

[Shield of Valor]. It's a Skill that [Knights] and other classes learn; a powerful tool for holding back the enemy or, it seems, creating an opening. The Hob loses his footing and Durene capitalizes on it. She swings her club up and down—

I shift my vision away, although part of me sees the splatter. The battle's over. The remaining Hob is smart enough to try to run, but he and the Goblins are boxed in now by their greed. Beniar runs down stragglers and the soldiers finish off the remaining Goblins, fighting defensively, wearing out their opponents rather than taking a risk. That's thanks to their leader, who calmly sits atop a horse from the back and blasts the Hob with small jolts of lightning until she—the Hob is female—drops with two swords in her belly.

It's over. I see Durene turning, wiping sweat with one hand as she rests her club against a wagon and the frightened [Traders] rushing towards my

little army, waving their hands, shouting their relief no doubt. There's no need to watch the rest; Wiskeria knows what to do.

I probably didn't need to watch after the second Hob went down, in point of fact. But I do worry. Whenever Durene fights I can't help but watch over her. That and make sure each battle is one stacked as heavily in her favor as possible.

That's all I can do. I sigh, and get up from the table I'm sitting at. It takes me a moment to center myself. Suddenly I'm not on the muddy road, but many, many miles east of there. I'm standing in Prost's house in a village known as Riverfarm, and I can hear the shouts and voices of countless people in the distance around me.

"That went well."

Slowly, I make my way towards the door and pause with my hand on the doorknob. I wait, and then open it slowly. Outside, I sense a man turn towards me and nod.

"Mister Prost? The battle is over."

"Over? That's quick, Your Majesty!"

"Yes, well, the Goblins attacked a bit sooner than Wiskeria thought. We were almost too late getting into position so there were a few casualties among the caravan. However, no one else died."

Prost's sigh of relief is huge. I nod towards him as I step out into the street. My feet slip a bit and Prost catches me before I can slip onto the ground. I steady myself and thank him as he lets go quickly. It wouldn't do for an [Emperor] to fall on his face now, would it?

Even though I can sense mud and other debris underfoot, I can't always predict what will happen. Plus, I'm bad about watching where I step when I

use my [Emperor] senses. For a blind man, there's probably nothing more ironic.

"Thank you, Prost. Please let everyone know what's happened. I'm sure Tessia will be relieved to know Gamel's alright."

"I will let her know directly, Your Majesty. Do you believe the caravan will continue onwards?"

I pause for a moment and cast my senses east again.

"I believe so. Yes, the wagons are already moving. Sensible of Wiskeria. They'll get to Trottsk within the hour, I think. Which will help immensely when we begin our negotiations with them."

"I should imagine so, sire."

Prost steps with me out of the muddy street, and I frown as I notice how much snow's already melted. Not that we get as much snow as some places on the continent, but it certainly makes for bad footing. There's mud everywhere, but ahead of me the ground feels...firmer for some reason. I frown as I try to make out what I'm sensing. Not dirt, but something else. Wood? What is it?

"I know we agreed that you should be the one to talk with them, Prost, but perhaps we should leave that to Wiskeria? I could alert her with a [Message] spell and I really can't afford for you to go, even for a day. We have so much to do—and I'm adding a paved street to our lists. This mud is too dangerous, and the last thing we need is for someone to slip and break something."

I can sense the man nodding. My [Steward] leads me onto a dryer patch of ground. Oh! Sawdust! That's what I was sensing. How sensible, and so much easier than digging up the entire street. Prost's ahead of me as usual.

“Yes, sire. I will make plans directly—we have a good deal of stone from the quarry we’ve set up, and I’m sure one of our [Diggers] has a stone-related skill. If not, there’s always mallets...but on the topic of sending someone to Trottvisk, Your Majesty, wouldn’t it be more appropriate for them to come to you?”

I pause and rub my chin.

“Perhaps. But I’d like to talk with them sooner rather than later. We could use a steady supply of goods, and if we wait for them to make the first move—”

Prost coughs gently and I break off. It’s interesting how we’ve developed a system already. He would never interrupt his own [Emperor], and yet, he does just that by coughing or making some other sound when I’m being an idiot. So I wait and let him speak.

“I think, sire, that it would be simplest to send a messenger requesting them to come here. You *are* an [Emperor], Your Majesty.”

“I—do you think they’d really come?”

“Certainly. [Lords] and [Ladies] do the same, and it would spare us having to send a party ourselves...”

“...And we get to negotiate on our own ground. Excellent idea, Prost.”

“I’ll see to it at once, Your Majesty.”

“Good. Now, we’ve expanded the totems to the roads between Trottvisk and Acran, but I’m still not sure about our northern borders. Obviously we don’t want to annex other villages, but can you have someone replant the markers down the...oh, the forked road just past Kiquel?”

I scratch my head.

“I can’t tell what’s at the crossroads there and it’s making me uneasy. And I know Jelov’s overworked, but I could *really* use another marker around that pond we found north of here. It gets fuzzy if they’re too far apart, and I could swear something is living down there...”

Prost follows along as I walk and talk. Around me, people call out, waving, speaking my name. Houses are going up, men and women are carrying wood and stone to new foundations, and in the distance, a group of [Farmers] is breaking new ground for fields. They want to plant now, and spring is only a month or so away by their reckoning.

I take it all in, part of me still amazed everything is happening. This is my empire. And it’s growing. Three villages are already pledged to me, including Riverfarm, and we’re building new houses as fast as we can to keep everyone under a roof. And if a *town* decides to join, well—

I’m lucky I like to stay busy.

Day 73

There is a dignity to being an [Emperor], but naturally that dignity is compromised according to each situation. I’m aware of the sins of hubris, and so I try to tell people that I’m as much of a man as I am a leader. With that said, I know the people of my village cherish my reputation, so I try to be dignified as well.

It’s debatable how well I do. For instance, I still live in Durene’s cottage because I love it there, and Durene and I need...special time now and then. The village is *not* a good place for privacy. Everyone wants to live near me, and though Kiquel and Tunslaven are still standing, people keep coming *here*. Because they feel safe.

I'm going to have to do something about that. I've already made plans with Prost to expand both villages when we have time. There are good pastures in Kiquel, and Tunslaven is too nice to abandon. However, it might be that Riverfarm eventually gets so big that both of the other villages become districts that are only a stone's throw away from the main empire. Now *that's* an intimidating thought.

Nevertheless, where was I? Intimacy. Right. Prost goes over every architectural decision with me and since I have a view of my entire kingdom in my head, I can organize the upcoming houses, fields, barns, and so on in a very efficient manner. I can also make it so that no new expansions are being built in the direction of Durene's cottage. That can stay as it is, thanks.

And yet, in public it's still on me to preserve my image as an [Emperor]. I can't walk around inspecting spots forever; I need a throne. Everyone says so, from Durene to Wiskeria to Gamel. Beniar doesn't, but he thinks I should have a chariot. I was against a throne since I want to be active, but we all found an...unusual compromise.

"Good morning, Emperor Laken!"

"Good day, sire!"

"Hello, Cinney. Good morning Siccy. Why is there an egg in your pocket?"

The young boy turns guiltily to me as I move through the village on my throne. He shuffles and clears his throat.

"It's a snack, sire! My ma boiled it and I was going to eat it, but I forgot—I'm sorry."

I smile at him.

“Ah. I see. Never mind then, I was just curious. Your mother’s quite smart—boiled eggs are a favorite snack of mine.”

“I’ll tell her you said so!”

Siccy’s bright voice makes me smile as I ride on. I can sense him watching me as I continue sitting on my throne. Yes, it’s certainly impressive. Eye-catching? Most definitely. Comfortable...not exactly.

I shift, and my ‘throne’ grunts a bit. It plods down the street and the villagers give it a respectful distance, but they’re used to the Mossbear enough by now to call out greetings to me as I pass by. One daring girl even offers my mobile throne a piece of dried jerky, giggling as it snuffs and licks her fingers. Her father scolds her for getting in my way, and I smile and wave.

Yeah. I ride the Mossbear around from time to time. It’s...regal? I’d grant that it’s impressive, but I personally feel like I’m in some kind of satire of a certain world leader each time I sit on the Mossbear. At least my bear is docile; I’d hate to try and ride him when he’s running about.

It’s thanks to my [Beast Tamer] class that I can have a bear as a throne, anyways. Or maybe my [Emperor] class *and* my [Beast Tamer] class? I can’t help but feel like a Level 9 [Beast Tamer] is a bit too low-level to have forged a bond with a bear already. But hey, what do I know? And speaking of animals with bonds—

“Frostwing!”

I raise my arm and call out. I sense a shape diving towards my arm and I’m glad Frostwing decides to land on the leather armguard rather than my shoulder this time. The large and, apparently, blue bird preens herself as I stroke her head.

“You’re learning to fly really well, aren’t you? Good job! Maybe now you’ll be able to feed yourself, rather than gobble meat all day. Would you like that? I can tell you’re going to poop now. Don’t do it on me, please, or the bear.”

A beak pecks at my fingers and I sigh. A tiny little tongue licks my fingers—Frostwing must have noticed the honey biscuit snack I had for lunch. A real treat I had to share with the bear as well. He’s a surprisingly docile fellow for someone so big. I’m told Mossbears camouflage themselves and attack deer when they get hungry. Or people. I’m just glad it’s possible to tame him with hot, buttery mashed potatoes.

“Okay, okay. You’re hungry and you’re a terrible hunter. Ow! Don’t peck. We’ll get you something to eat. Let’s all just go see Prost, okay? *Prost*. That way.”

I nudge the bear mentally and with my legs and he ambles left. Frostwing flutters down to land on his back and sits with me as we proceed down the street. The bear. I haven’t come up with a good name for him yet. I’m thinking something German would be nice, but I’m really not inspired. And he’s not exactly fussed—it’s just that having [Lesser Bond: Unnamed Mossbear] in my head is a bit...well, I feel bad for him.

“Emperor Laken, good morning, sire!”

“Prost. What have we here? Hello Durene, we meet again.”

“Laken!”

Durene turns as I approach a cleared space with a lot of wood, nails, and busy people hammering and cutting wood. My half-Troll lover reaches up and strokes the Mossbear’s head. He whuffs at her as Frostwing caws impatiently. Prost edges around both bear and bird as I slide off and coughs nervously. I think he’s afraid of both animals, which is perfectly understandable. I step to one side and investigate the scene with my senses.

“That’s a lot of wood. A lot of nails and screws, too. Do you think you have all the materials you need?”

Prost hesitates. He glances around.

“I think Mister Helm’d be the better man to speak to that, sire, but I see he’s busy. I’m not an expert, but from what he and the other [Carpenters] and [Blacksmiths] say, building this...thing should be easy.”

“Trebuchet, Mister Prost. It’s called a trebuchet.”

“Yes sir. I’ve never heard of it, as I said, and the other folk say they haven’t either. Then again, you hear about odd weapons being used in Chandrar and Baleros—do you think we can truly make it, sire?”

I have to hesitate.

“Possibly, Mister Prost. It’s worth a shot at any rate. I uh, can’t read the designs Ryoka gave me, but you told me they look good?”

“Oh, yes sir. It’s a very simple design. It’s just the size of it that’s stumping us, sir. You say these things are meant to hurl blocks of stone hundreds of feet away? I’ve heard of magical catapults that couldn’t do the same!”

“Well, these *are* siege weapons, Prost. In fact, I’d prefer a catapult, but Ryoka couldn’t remember how uh, torsion siege weapons were made. Trebuchets are a lot easier, according to her. Someone apparently made one out of duct tape once.”

“Duck tape?”

“Never mind. If you think you can make one, I’d love to use it on any attackers. Put it on wheels, maybe make them smaller since we’re not exactly firing at castles here and...well, why not? Just think about it, Prost.

Six of these aimed at a group of Goblins and we wouldn't have to fight a battle."

"I can't argue with that, sire. And it's such a simple thing too. One arm goes up, a heavy block goes on the other end, and it all rests on this uh—"

"Fulcrum."

"Yes, that. I'm most worried about whether the wood will stand up to all the weight, sire. Our first trial broke the fulcrum thing as you know. However, the lads—and the three ladies—are very excited about it. Miss Tessia's almost as keen as the boys are to see this thing throw something. And on that note, I learned yesterday that *three* of our folk have a new class, sir!"

Prost leans over and whispers to me confidentially.

"They're [Tinkerers], sir. Not [Engineers] like you'd hoped, but I'm told that's the first step. To have three in one village, well, it's extraordinary. Begging your pardon, of course, I know you'd hoped for more."

I shake my head, smiling broadly.

"That's great news, Prost. I didn't think [Engineers] were that likely, but I'd hoped, that's all. You see, to gain the [Engineer] class I think the people would need the right tools, more knowledge about how to build things, and perhaps the right mindset. As it is, the [Tinkerer] class will probably become [Engineer] about, oh, I'd say Level 15 or so. So there's nothing to worry about."

I can tell Prost is giving me an admiring look. It's completely undeserved.

"You know so much, Emperor. How did you learn about so many classes?"

I cough. I might have said too much. I hesitate over my reply.

“Someone...told me, Prost. Anyways, these [Tinkerers] have useful Skills?”

“Yes, sire. Tessia learned [Detect Flaw], which is a great help in itself. It’s a Skill that lets her know if we’ve cut something wrong or there’s rot in the wood and so on...I wouldn’t mind her going to all of our houses later on to check on them as well.”

“I think that’s a fine idea. At your discretion, Prost. Now, I know Durene’s helping you lift things, but could you spare her later on? I haven’t had much time to see her after she got back.”

I can sense Prost’s posture shift, and I studiously ignore the small smile on his face.

“Yes, sire. I could let her go right now—”

“No, no. I wouldn’t want to get in the way.”

I cough again, and turn away. An [Emperor]’s dignity. I try not to blush. I turn back to the Mossbear as Prost returns to the construction and sigh. When everyone and their dog knows about your relationship—and worse, now approves of it and actively tries to give you space—it’s nearly as bad as the prejudice.

Seid doch nicht so pervers. At least today I got to see the trebuchet fire. True, the rock went nearly straight up and crushed half of our experimental model. Prost and I concluded that the testing had better be done from far away using a long rope—and everyone should wear helmets just in case. But it’s a start. Hell, more than one. I’m building trebuchets now. Where does it stop?

I guess this kind of technology will help level the field against [Mages]. Our best mage is Wiskeria, and she’s a [Witch]. That’s a concern for later,

though. Our new empire is still stronger than it has any right to be. Hopefully all these little tricks—the palisades we keep rebuilding further and further out, the network of totems, my ‘eyes’, and things like the trebuchets—will keep us safe, keep my people safe from now on.

And maybe if no one else dies, the nightmares I’ve been having will someday stop.

Day 74

Today I had my first audience. It was spontaneous—I didn’t realize the messenger had arrived until he was riding in on horseback—largely informal, and took place while I was sitting on my throne. The Mossbear. Given those circumstances, I can’t see how it *couldn’t* have been a success.

“I’m deeply grateful for the gifts, from Trotvisk, Mister Rencil. And I understand the trading caravan gave my people several tokens of their appreciation as well. However, it was our pleasure to help fight the Goblins. They are a common enemy that transcends alliances and feuds.”

“Just as you say, Your Majesty. But we are deeply grateful for your protection. I, ah, am instructed to tell you these are only the smallest representations of our esteem. Our town did not know there was such an—an esteemed personage so close by, or we would have sent a delegation earlier, of course.”

The [Messenger] stammers as he tries to control his nervous horse around my bear. I smile and dismount. I think my closed eyes bother the young man on horseback as much as the bear.

“Please, allow me to offer you some refreshments and food. It’s the least I can do.”

“You are too kind si—I mean, Your Majesty. However, I couldn’t intrude. I’m—I was only instructed to deliver the gifts and report b—I mean, return at full speed.”

He’s stumbling over himself and almost falls over himself as he hands Prost the gifts—some wax candles, a bundle of fine cloth, and a bottle of some kind of drink. Probably alcohol. He clearly doesn’t think it’s a fitting gift, but I don’t really care. Mainly, I’m a bit concerned that my reputation as an [Emperor] has spread so far already. Rumor and gossip are one thing, but how—

Ah. Wiskeria and my soldiers must have talked. Drat. Regardless, I smile up at the man and offer him my hand. He fumbles with his glove and his hand is sweaty as it grasps mine.

“I shall await the delegation eagerly. I feel that mutual ties between my empire and Trottsvisk would be beneficial for us both. You may know that my army keeps the area around my empire safe from monsters and bandits—I would like to do the same for your towns with their permission.”

“I will tell them that at once, Your Majesty. I’m sure we could provide you with anything needful—we have lots of goods—for your protection.”

“Uh, that wasn’t what I—”

Too late. The messenger is already promising me whatever Trottsvisk can offer if we’ll keep the Goblins from sacking their town. I sigh over it later when he’s gone, but Prost and the others are approving. Protection for tributes. It feels wrong, but Wiskeria puts it into plainer terms for me.

“You have a finite force at your disposal, Your Majesty. Fighting battles—even ones where you know the enemy is coming—will cost you time and lives. Why shouldn’t other towns offer you some sort of support for your protection? Going out of your way to keep the roads patrolled is enough of

a boon as it is. Normally adventurers have to be paid vast sums to do the same.”

“I suppose you’re right, Wiskeria. And on that note, I hope you can find more recruits soon. We have half a dozen adventurers, around fifty warriors and archers, you, Durene, and...a Mossbear as our standing forces. That’s not exactly reassuring if a larger group of Goblins comes calling.”

My [General] nods calmly. She’s rarely in the village, often dealing with a threat or talking to other villages, but I trust her perhaps most of all my close advisors because she is so competent. She’s taken to her role as well as Prost has.

“Beniar knows some adventurers and I have my own contacts, but I believe we’ll find the most success recruiting old veterans and training new warriors from the villagers. The army might be small now, but it is substantially more powerful than most towns’ militias, in my opinion.”

“True. But we need more gear. If all we have is weapons taken from Goblins...well, let me know if there are any more [Knights] you would like me to dub. I think I could make about ten more.”

Wiskeria shifts as she laces her fingers together and frowns slightly.

“I think it might be best to wait, Your Majesty. I understand Gamel and the others are leveling quickly and that [Knights] are far superior to [Warriors], but if they are limited—”

“—I should wait for truly promising recruits. I understand.”

I grimace. Making [Knights]. Of course, it’s not without their consent and each person I’ve dubbed has told me how honored they are—Gamel still seems stunned and his girlfriend, Tessia, is over the moon about it—but it still feels wrong. Like I’m forcing them to become something they’re not.

“Emperor Laken?”

“Hm? I’m sorry, Wiskeria. I drifted off there. What were you saying?”

Silently, the [Witch] offers me a cup of the tea she brews and keeps in canteens at her saddlebags. I accept it gratefully—she brews *very* strong tea which has more caffeine in it than coffee. It also has a very refreshing minty taste.

“I was saying that appointing [Lords] and [Ladies] might lure in even Gold-rank teams, if you so choose. Their loyalty might be bought, but if you’re concerned, I could ask about trustworthy groups...”

Her tone is cautious. I frown, but not because I’m disagreeing with her. Appointing...? Oh, right. That’s a good idea. But...alas. I sigh.

“Unfortunately, Wiskeria, I don’t have any more such titles to give out, at least not now. I could probably name one or two more [Lords] and [Ladies], but nothing more. I, uh, gave the other titles away to save my village a while ago.”

“I see.”

She’s looking at me with that piercing, inquisitive gaze. And adjusting her spectacles. I keep my face smooth. I trust Wiskeria a lot after it was revealed Odveig was the spy and she was loyal all along, but telling someone about making a bunch of Frost Faeries [Baronesses] and so on is a bit...well, let’s just say that it’s not exactly a ringing endorsement of mental health.

“I’m willing to offer other groups land, or some kind of title, but I’d rather have people who are loyal rather than here for personal gain, Wiskeria.”

“I understand. In that regard I think we’ll be fine either way.”

“Oh? Why’s that?”

Wiskeria counters my raised eyebrow with one of her own. She nods towards the door. I gave Wiskeria one of the first new houses we constructed, but she's already hinting she'd like a personal home when we finish building the essentials. That's fair. Her neighbors are already complaining of the smells her witch brews create.

"You just received a messenger from Trottvisk, Your Majesty. I imagine the other nearby villages and towns will have heard about that and your army, and will be sending their own envoys shortly. I expect at least one village will pledge themselves to you, and there will certainly be at least a handful of older warriors among their number. And that's besides the gifts you'll receive."

I cough on the tea.

"You think so? But we already got tributes—"

She shrugs dismissively.

"Tokens of esteem. Tributes for an *[Emperor]* would be far more substantial, I imagine. Which is why spreading word of your name and class is important."

I stare at her. Well, turn my head towards her while keeping my eyes closed. It's practically the same thing.

"Did you plan all this ahead of time, Wiskeria? Is that why rumors about me keep spreading?"

She only smiles and sips at her tea. Witches. They're so...mysterious.

Day 76

Goblins attacked a distant village and burnt it to the ground. The people were slaughtered or taken prisoner. I heard about this through a [Message] spell sent to Wiskeria. There was no word on how many Goblins attacked or if there were Hobs, but I told Jelov I needed more markers done *now*.

There is a limit to how much ‘space’ each marker can cover. We need more to extend our vision past the few towns and villages around my empire. Winning a battle is all about knowing where the enemy is coming from, with as much advanced notice as possible. If a large force does come here...we have to be able to set traps, lay in ambush. We don’t have the soldiers yet—

But I am leveling up. And if I need to I will fight. Order my villagers to fight, even when their bodies are spent. Even if that means seeing more of the dead faces in my dreams.

Day 77

The delegation arrived on horseback around midmorning, as I was about to visit Jelov the [Carver]. I would have seen them right away, but Prost insisted there was a formality to everything. He had their horses stabled and the visitors given a meal in the newly-built townhouse that also doubles as the main storehouse and kitchen, and I went to visit Jelov in the meantime.

“Your Majesty, I’m so happy to see you! Can I offer you a seat? Whoops, there’s a chisel there...and that’s no good—let me just brush off some wood shavings here. Please, please, have a seat!”

I smile and sit as the [Carver] sidles around me, fussing over me. I get him to sit only after a lot of coaxing. But then, it’s probably only natural that Jelov is glad to see me. My usage of the marker totems that define my

territory—and thus the limits of my [Emperor]’s sight—have made him an important man in the village, where before he was something of a hermit.

Now he has his own house, respect, and two apprentices. Jelov practically gushes all this out as he sits a bit too close to me, and I recall why I don’t visit him all the time. Spit is good for the skin. I keep telling Durene that.

“I’m working on more markers as we speak, sire, but my hands ache so. I carve all day, which isn’t to say it’s not worth doing! But I’m afraid you can’t rush art.”

I smile. Art. Each totem Jelov comes out with is subtly different. The symbol at the top is always the same, of course—it’s the illuminati eye, known as the Eye of Providence. But Jelov takes liberties carving the rest of the eight-foot totems, sometimes illustrating battles, sometimes carving names or other weird symbols into the wood—I don’t mind, and he clearly feels like uniform totems would be a crime.

“I understand you’re working your hardest, Master Jelov. And I’m not here to demand more of you—rather, I wanted to know about a little rumor I’ve been hearing. Something about miniature carved totems popping up around the village with my symbol on it?”

“Ah.”

Jelov gulps audibly. I put my cup to one side and turn my head towards him.

“What’s this about, Jelov?”

“Well—it’s nothing sire. Just a little sideshow, a distraction. A hobby more like. It’s just these—why don’t I show you one? Here?”

He rushes about his workshop and comes back with several objects that are all about the size of my hand. I study them in my mind’s eye. They’re...

well, they're scaled down models of the markers, carved in the same way, polished and rounded down at the edges.

"Miniature markers?"

"Totems, sir. Just like you said. Trinkets, really. It's just a little thing I've been doing for the other folk who live here."

"Why?"

He sounds surprised.

"Why, because they ask for them sire! Everyone wants one of these in their homes. They think it gives good luck. Or protection! If I wasn't carving these large markers I'd be making these little ones all day. The demand's through the roof! Err—not that I take time off to make them, not at all! These are just a bedtime occupation. A bit of carving between the sheets, before I sleep, sire. Honest!"

I have to shake my head. I know the markers are essential and people take pride in this empire and me, but this? I pick up one of the little totems Jelov's carved and frown as I trace the etchings on the wood.

"You say people want this, Jelov, but how do they pay for it? No one has any money to spare—unless they're giving you something else?"

It was a hesitant request, but the villagers gladly gave me what little they had. I in turn traded with the various towns for more food, more supplies on their behalf. What was left over Prost insisted was mine, as I ruled everyone. Jelov crabs sideways, and his voice is...shifty.

"Well, y'see Your Majesty, there's coin and then there's a bite of food, some fresher pillows, maybe a scented candle...small things to exchange, you know? There's no harm in it."

"Bartering. Of course. But if people need money—"

“There’s time enough for that when we’re all eating rich, milord. Us simple folk just like having something to give and take with our spare time, that’s all.”

Jelov’s voice is surprisingly firm. I hesitate, and then relent and put the half-finished totem down.

“Just don’t let it take too much time, Jelov. And tell people the totems don’t work like they’ll hope. I can’t see everywhere at once and I wouldn’t even if I could.”

“Ah, you say that sire, but didn’t you rescue little Evvy when that old wall collapsed onto her? You were shouting for people to dig her out before we’d even noticed she was missing!”

“That was luck, Jelov. I can’t do it every time.”

“Once or twice is better than none, Your Majesty. And a bit of hope’s what folk like. Not to mention my carvings look good on the mantelpiece or by the bed.”

“I *wish* they wouldn’t put them there.”

“Why?”

I bite my lip on my reply. People are people, and I can’t help what I sense. But having an image of a couple...or trio...having sex in vivid details is *not* one of my interests, thank you. Villagers they might be, but the people of my empire have surprisingly kinky tastes. I could have lived without knowing that.

“Never mind. Why don’t they put them by the windows? That’s a very proper place for it. Far from the bedrooms. Maybe over the mantel?”

“You’d know best, wouldn’t you, sire?”

Jelov twinkles at me and I glumly resign myself. At least there's no real harm in it, and if people like it—I turn as Jelov lifts up a tiny carved illuminati eye on a round wood ball with a flat base.

“Now this is a little trinket I came up with yesterday. Very small and convenient it is. Perfect for a pocket or as a gift. I'm told some folks are making their own—not as good as mine, of course—and sending them to relatives.”

“*Wonderful.*”

“You think so? I think it could use a bit of color, myself. Do you want one, milord? I could get one painted and all special like. Maybe as a gift for Miss Durene?”

“I'll think about it, Jelov. Just don't let your hobby overtake your work.”

Sighing, I leave the [Carver]'s shop behind. Little illuminati totems. And people *want* them staring at them. What next? Well, next is arguably less fun. I wipe the spit off the side of my face, and then begin the negotiations.

They go well. Riverfarm, or rather, the Unseen Empire might not produce any agricultural goods, or trade goods, or any goods of any kind at the moment, but we're currently the most powerful force in the area. And because I can see everything in my territory, I can promise safety without it being a lie. It's funny how much people are willing to offer for that.

Day 78

Word spreads quickly about the Goblin attacks. Two more delegations arrived and another village, Batte, asked for my protection. I couldn't give it. They were too far away. So the villages decided to come *here*.

Now the three closest towns and almost all of the villages accessible in a day's journey are under my protection. Under the protection of eighty-some warriors and Wiskeria, a [General], but a low-level one. My champion is Durene, a Level 14 [Paladin]. I'm worried. But Wiskeria comes by with a proposal, and it's such a good plan that we send out messengers that night to each town and village. We have a plan in case the Goblins come in force. I hope we never have to use it.

Day 79

"Delivery for...Emperor Laken Godart? Yes, sir. My name is Thasius Griff. I am a City Runner from Invril. I have a delivery—several deliveries for you, Your Majesty. Do you have a seal?"

I stare at the City Runner in front of me. My eyes drift sideways to Prost. The man shakes his head and grimaces. I look back at Thasius.

"No. Should I?"

"It isn't required, Your Majesty, but a specialized and unique seal for our uh, wealthier clientele speeds up our deliveries. May I ask you to place your hand on this truth stone and declare your name?"

"Certainly. I am Laken Godart."

There's a delicate pause. Thasius coughs. I wait a beat. So, that's what they want, is it?

"I am an [Emperor]."

"Thank you, your...Your Majesty."

After a brief moment of hesitation, the smooth stone is taken back. Thasius steps backwards and fumbles with his bag of holding, a bit more

hesitant than before. I tilt my head. I can't see inside the bag of holding with my [Emperor] senses, so I'm as curious as my advisors around me.

My advisors. That means Beniar, Wiskeria, Durene, Prost, and Gamel. In truth, Beniar's more my cavalry leader, but he's a solid adventurer and he sometimes has good advice. Durene's here because I love her. Prost and Wiskeria are both intelligent and run my empire. And Gamel's here because I want him to be here.

"I have—excuse me—I have several gifts from various clients, Your Majesty. If you will allow me, I will present them one at a time so you may confirm delivery."

"May I ask who sent each gift?"

Thasius nods. He's holding the first parcel in his hands, some wrapped, bulky set of objects.

"Each client specifically requested their name be mentioned with their gifts, Your Majesty. There is no request for a return message, but I will deliver any verbal or physical replies free of charge as part of the service."

"I see. Very well then."

The City Runner nods and clears his throat.

"The first gift I have is from the Merchant's Guild in Invrisil. They offer you their profound thanks for rescuing two of their caravans from Goblin and monster attack respectively, and offer you a small gift as their thanks."

He unwraps the cloth parcel to reveal...bottles. I frown at them, sensing the liquid inside.

"Forgive me. I cannot see what these, ah, gifts are. Prost? Will you tell me what they contain?"

Prost steps forwards and the City Runner offers him the bottles. There's a moment of fumbling, and Prost's voice catches.

"These are—healing potions, Your Majesty. High-quality ones. And this is a—a perfume?"

Thasius coughed delicately.

"Scented oils, I believe. And this one is a potion of Armorskin, a powerful one. I believe they're the same quality as the ones used by Gold-rank adventurers."

"We can certainly use them."

Wiskeria murmurs in my ear. I nod, but keep my face straight. I know my reactions are being watched by Thasius, so I nod while showing little emotion.

"An expensive gift. Please return my thanks to the Merchant's Guild and assure them that I hope for continued prosperity between my people and theirs. What else do you bring?"

"A gift from a [Merchant], Your Majesty. Specially scented soaps."

"Soaps?"

Yes, soaps. Some are clear red, others are light purple, one's pink... Durene and Wiskeria touch them, exclaiming over them softly so I let them take the bundle. Soaps. Apparently they're *very* expensive. And this merchant's sending them to me as a gift.

Hmm. This time I just nod towards Thasius.

"Please thank your client for the expensive gifts."

I don't mention the [Merchant]'s name or go on. And Thasius notices. And I notice that he notices. Now I think I've got the tune of this game, so I

go on.

Eight gifts were sent my way, from eight people who live in the general area of Invril or nearby. And, coincidentally, each one was delivered at once. Was it the Runner's Guild who arranged that? Or were the roads not safe until now?

Curious. I recognize two of the gifts as being from the same senders as the letters I'd received over a week ago. I remember thinking hard over what to do with each letter, but I eventually did exactly what I'd been advised to do.

My reply to the various letters I'd received had been uniform, polite denials to their requests to meet. I'd told each person, from the [Merchants] to the nobles, that I was busy, invited them to pay me a visit at their convenience and so on and so forth, and expressed my best wishes for the future. I'd signed it simply as 'Laken Godart' and not added any titles.

It seemed like the thing to do. Pique interest, keep them occupied wondering what my game was, and move on with the important business while they schemed. And so, after a week of waiting, the next move these powerful figures did was to offer me gifts. And while some were useless, like the soaps and received my scant thanks in return, others were intriguing.

"This comes from Lady Rie, Your Majesty."

Thasius has to struggle with his next delivery and for good reason. I blink as he pulls out a long, long package and small wrapped parcels of powder, tiny vials, and most curious of all—

"Milk?"

Yes, several large jugs of goat's milk. I stare at the odd collection of items that sits on the table in front of me, and Thasius explains.

“Lady Rie delivered a short message with the gifts. She understands Your Majesty is uh—uh—”

“Blind?”

“Um. Yes. So she ordered me to deliver the message verbally. It is as follows.”

I sense Thasius closing his eyes and he speaks slowly and carefully.

“To [Emperor] Laken, I am Lady Rie Valerund of Invril. I offer you my greetings and hope that the people you have chosen to protect fare well in these troubled times. I understand you have taken several villages under your aegis, and offer these medicines, ointments, and powders that have been created to ease children into this world. The young are our future, and the taxing requirements of raising them should be lessened if at all possible. I hope and trust we shall meet in the future as circumstances allow. I wish you the best of luck in your endeavors, Lady Rie.”

The young man is panting when he finishes. I stare at the gift Lady Rie has sent me. Piles of—of—baby powder? And milk? I can’t help it.

I laugh. The sound makes Thasius start, but then I stand up. For a second I debate making him memorize a reply of my own, but then I relent.

“Please tell Lady Rie that I am most grateful for her thoughtful—and insightful gift. I would welcome a meeting between us and hope I can return her gift in time. I am most humbly in her debt as Emperor Laken of the Unseen Empire.”

Chuckling, I sit down. Thasius stares at me before scrambling to break the next gift out. That night I share around soaps, candied treats, and other goodies. I don’t really want any of the things myself, and Wiskeria can use the potions. The only thing I keep is three of the soaps. They’re useful and Durene wants to use them. We try the first soap that night and conclude that

the soaps are good, but we need a bigger bathtub. A hot tub would be *very* nice.

Day 80

The trebuchet arm broke, but at least we knocked down a tree. Now, if only we could aim the damned thing. Ryoka said the arm had to be...what was it? A ratio of 1:3.75? That's really hard to put into practice.

And yet, a trebuchet...I see Tessia's eyes shining as she fires a tiny prototype, and it sends a rock flying across the village. It's a good idea. I just have to make sure none of the kids make models of the trebuchet themselves. The stone brained Mister Helm and nearly cracked his skull.

Day 81

Another town attacked. This one fought the Goblins off, but at a heavy cost. The attacks are all coming from around a mountain far to the east, and there's a rumor going around that some kind of Great Chieftain of the Goblins lives there. All the better—or worse, I suppose. A Great Chieftain sounds bad, but if they're further away, it means raiding parties won't bother to travel this far. We'd have to have something they really wanted for them to attack, and the Unseen Empire's greatest asset is that we're poor.

We're poor. Hold on, what's moving down the north road? It's just at the limits of my senses, but it feels like it's headed north. And isn't that where...?

Day 82

The attack was sudden, fierce, and came at dawn. Over two hundred and twenty Goblins poured out of the snowy landscape, and *twenty six* Hobs were leading them. It was a force that might take a town, or raze a village in less than an hour. But it was not a village nor a town that was attacked.

It was a mansion. Nestled comfortably adjacent to a small town, the home of Lady Rie and the Valerund family's estate was, in theory, safe from bandits. The magical wards on the walls and the lady's own private guard were more than a match for any monster or bandit attack.

But not Goblins. A [Shaman] blasted the wards off as the other Goblins swarmed through the town, setting it alight. Hobs cut down the shocked defenders as people fled towards the mansion.

No one made it.

The Goblins encircled the mansion, pounding on walls, trying to break the magically-reinforced glass. One Hob managed to bash through a window, but magefire and a hail of arrows dissuaded other Goblins from entering that way. Too dangerous. Instead, the [Shaman] began dancing in front of the door and the remaining Hobs brought out the battering rams. They began pounding on the doors as the lesser Goblins around them shouted, whipped into a frenzy by the [Shaman]'s dancing and spells.

Inside the mansion, Lady Rie Valerund and what remained of her guard sat and counted weapons. They had few bows, although there was a surplus of arrows for each one. Her servants and protectors were all gripping weapons, but they were only good steel, not enchanted. The Valerund family was not heir to the Reinhart legacy, and their bloodline had been whittled down over the years to one sole member.

The scion of the Valerund blood sat in one of her upholstered chairs and looked towards the captain of her guard. He, a brawny man who'd been an

accomplished [Street Brawler] before she'd met him, was injured. Blood ran thickly down one arm before he poured a splash of healing potion on the wound. Lady Rie eyed the bloodstains on her carpet and said not a word about it.

“Have you sent a [Message] spell to Invrisil, to Lady Reinhart?”

She turned to her [Mage], a young man who had attended Wistram but failed to receive his mage certification. The pale-faced man nodded.

“I did—but they said that help won't arrive for hours yet!”

“In which time we shall be dead. And Lady Reinhart?”

Lady Rie's face was calm. Only one shaking leg betrayed her, but she kept the motion hidden by one of her gowns. Her captain of the guard, the man who'd been known as Geram Redfist, looked at his mistress and then away. The young [Mage] gulped.

“She—was unavailable, my lady. I tried and tried, but the [Mage] who answered said—said there was nothing she could do anyways.”

Rie tapped at one lip thoughtfully. A loud *thump* echoed down the corridors and her face paled, but she went on as if she hadn't heard.

“Either her magical carriages have broken down again or her staff are... indisposed. No aid from her then. It seems the Goblins will break in within the hour. Unless I am wrong, Geram?”

The big man lowered his head. He carried no weapons, but he had two gauntlets on each hand and he had beaten the Hob who'd entered to death with his bare fists.

“They'll be in sooner than that, Miss Rie. That damn [Shaman]'s creating something big out there and the Hobs are breaking the doors bit by bit.”

Lady Rie bit her lip.

“I thought those enchantments were meant to hold a Troll off. They were Wistram-certified. Nesor, you told me they were *powerful*.”

Nesor, the young [Mage], gulped.

“They are, Lady Rie. But—but no enchantment lasts forever! If you could shoot the Goblins or—or chase them away, the magic might replenish. I could cast a spell—”

Geram shook his head.

“Open a window and you’ll be filled with arrows before you can raise your hands, boy. There are Goblins climbing the roof. They’re banging on the windows upstairs.”

“They won’t get in, surely.”

Rie looked at Geram. He shrugged.

“Before the Hobs bust down the doors? No.”

She understood what he was saying. And what he wasn’t saying. Rie looked around, at the frightened faces around her and stood up slowly.

“Well then. It appears we all have an engagement with destiny. My loyal staff, Geram, Nesor, it has been a pleasure, truly.”

The gathered servants, [Maids], lone [Gardener], and [Cook] stared at their mistress in horror. She looked around and sighed.

“For all my scheming and plans, I didn’t expect it to end like this. Not... not so inelegantly.”

“We’ll hold them off as long as we can. I’ve already barricaded the main corridor and we’ve got every bow at each end. We’ll make them bleed before they get to us, I swear.”

Geram clenched one fist as the thundering blows on the door intensified. Outside the Goblins screamed and the [Shaman] roared a word that made the silverware on the tables flash for a second. Rie flinched. Geram looked towards Nesor and the [Mage] hesitated before hurrying towards the makeshift barricades. The captain of the guard drew closer to Rie and lowered his voice. He took something off of his belt and handed it to her.

Rie stared at the object. It was a dagger. She looked up at Geram's face. The man's expression was grim.

"I won't lie, Lady Rie, there's no way out for us. I could try opening a window and making a break for it, but the Goblins would catch us before we went half a yard. As for holding here—we don't have the manpower for it."

She nodded and tried to laugh lightly.

"I suppose I should have hired that Silver-rank team like you'd always advised me, shouldn't I, Geram?"

He smiled back. Someone screamed and his head turned. It was only a servant, seeing a Goblin's face pressed against one of the windows. He shook his head.

"Three Silver-rank teams wouldn't have made a difference, milady. But here."

He offered her the dagger again. Rie stared at it.

"For me? I'm sure I'll fight my best Geram, but I'm no warrior. If there's someone who can use it better—"

"We're all armed, milady. No. This is for the last."

Geram's bald head was sweating. He looked into Rie's eyes.

“I’ll die fighting, with a Goblin’s throat in my hands. But milady, the Goblins are known to capture—that is, take women prisoner and—”

Lady Rie’s face paled further. Geraam hastily raised a hand in case she fainted, but she caught herself.

“I see. I understand Geraam, but that won’t be necessary.”

“But Lady Rie—”

She drew something out of her pocket with trembling hands. Geraam stared at the viscous orange liquid within. Rie smiled bitterly.

“We all have plans for the end, Geraam. In this case, this poison will kill me quicker than any dagger. And better, it will poison my body. If I am to die, I will make sure any...indignities...are repaid in kind.”

The bald man looked at Rie and smiled. He offered her a hand and Rie took it as if she were being led onto the dance floor at a ball. The two proceeded towards the barricade. Heads turned to follow them as they walked. Geraam lowered his head towards her as he walked.

“It has been an honor to serve you, my lady. I was nothing until I met you.”

Rie whispered.

“Nonsense. You were always worthy. Now. It is time.”

The doors were splintering. The Hobs roared as they smashed the battering ram into it again and again. The magic wards were failing. Rie turned and raised her voice. It could hardly be heard above the shrieking of the Goblins just outside, or the pounding at the doors, but still her words reached each one of her servants.

“Ladies, gentlemen, this is it. The end. I am afraid we will die here. Perhaps horribly. And that is our fate.”

They stared at her. Lady Rie's chin lifted. The shaking in her knees stopped.

"Did you expect otherwise? No. I did not. No matter how much we beg or plead, there is no mercy here. This is *Izril*. Here we fight and live and die without respite, all of us. Life is a battle. We use words like knives and fight with politics and swords. None of us are ever safe, and it is an illusion to say otherwise."

She paused. A thundering roar came from outside. Rie closed her eyes, and then opened them. She looked each of her servants in the face.

"But remember this. *We will be avenged*. Because *that* is Izril as well. We repay death with death. These Goblins may win today, but they will not celebrate long. We will be avenged. Remember that, and sell your lives wisely—"

"*Milady!*"

Nesor's voice, desperate and shrill. Rie closed her eyes. He had lost his grip, the poor child. She opened her mouth, tried to speak over him.

"Remember that! Do not give the Goblins any quarter—"

"*Milady Rie!*"

"Silence!"

Geram roared at the young [Mage]. He strode over to Nesor, and froze as the [Mage] pointed out the window. He stared. Rie turned, aware that something was happening.

"What's going on? Nesor? Geram?"

No one answered her. Rie strode over to one of the windows. Her first impression was a heaving sea of green bodies, but then her eyes focused on something in the distance. They widened.

“What on earth...?”

There was another sound. Rie turned left and saw Nesor falling backwards. His eyes were flickering and she saw the telltale signs of an incoming [Message] spell. He gasped and she rushed over to him.

“What is it?”

“It’s—a [Message]. To you. Lady Rie. It says—says—”

Nesor was a poor [Mage], unable to process [Message] spells like an experienced spellcaster. Normally Rie didn’t care, but at the moment she couldn’t bear to wait. She shook him impatiently.

“Well? Out with it!”

The young man choked. Gera pulled Rie back, and then Nesor’s head rose. He spoke slowly, each word ringing in the sudden silence outside.

“Lady Rie. I thank you for your gift. Though it is humble, I seek to return the favor. In this dire hour, I offer you the gift of swords.”

Slowly, Rie’s head rose. She looked back towards the window and all the pieces fell into place. She walked towards the windows and saw the army, shining as it marched towards the Goblins. She breathed the words slowly.

“Emperor Laken.”

An army halts within range of the mansion. I have to pause when I see the numbers. Over a hundred—two hundred Goblins. And so many Hobs! And one of them is a powerful spellcaster.

It's a force that could swallow Riverfarm whole. Far greater than the last one we faced or any since. And normally I wouldn't dare risk my army fighting them. But it's not just my army here.

Wiskeria gallops her horse forwards. Her voice is a shout that echoes as Goblins break away from pounding on the mansion's doors and stream towards us.

"[Archers], aim! Hold, *hold* I said! Wait for them to draw nearer. Cavalry, on my signal! Infantry, brace!"

A hundred bows rise at her order. A hundred. Or more. I didn't count. They're not our bowmen, not just ours, at any rate. No, they're [Guardsmen], retired [Hunters], warriors, even a few adventurers. From each town and village we could reach. And not just them. Rows of armored [Warriors] brace themselves in a line while mounted warriors line up. They're carrying banners, and Beniar's voice rises with Wiskeria's. He trots them left as the Goblins approach.

"Loose!"

A shower of arrows shoots upwards. Goblins scream and race towards us, some returning fire. Bodies jerk and tumble downwards. The Hobs are charging from the front. I see Durene standing tall, her shield and club in hand.

I'm at the back. I raise my hand as I hear a rumbling growl next to me. The Mossbear roars as the Goblins stream at us.

"Wait. Not yet. Wait..."

Wiskeria is shouting.

"Loose!"

Another flight. Now Beniar's cavalry circles the Goblins, searching for their flanks. I see the Goblin [Shaman] dancing, casting huge jets of fire at the riders, burning them. From our midst, several robed figures with wands loose spells at the [Shaman].

And then they're here. The Goblins charge into our ranks. Wiskeria turns and points. The soldiers surge forwards. My hand tightens on the Mossbear's fur for a second.

"Go!"

He roars and charges forwards. Durene is trading blows with a Hob, and I stand, watching the battle in my mind's eye. It's all hazy. The markers are barely working. But I'm waiting. Wiskeria shouts my name.

"Laken! Now!"

"Kneel."

My words break across the Goblins as Beniar charges into their midst. Some fall to their knees. Others just hesitate. The soldiers cut down the hesitating Goblins and charge forwards. I stand where I am.

An army. Over four hundred soldiers all told, including our forces. A levy. I stare towards the mansion where Lady Rie lives, a hazy shape in my mind's eye. Is it worth the cost? Is it worth the dying men and women around me? I don't know. But the Goblins are a threat. And so I raise my finger.

The [Shaman] is laughing, blocking spells with one hand and shooting globs of acid that melt the soldiers fighting around me. Wiskeria is blasting Hobs with lightning, and the archers' arrows swerve before they reach the [Shaman]. I point at the laughing Goblin and speak into his ears.

"Look this way."

He does. His head turns towards me and his attention wavers. I see him frown, then turn his head, eyes widening. Too late. Beniar rushes towards him and leaps from his horse. My [Cataphract], my [Captain], impales the [Shaman] with his sword and falls to the ground, hacking at the Goblin. I stand as the bloodbath continues. I am Laken, and this is my war.

I can sense each soldier that falls. I hear them screaming. Some beg for life, others curse the Goblins as they die. Others die silent, surprised. But never alone.

I hear them all. And I do not ask them for more. Not today. The battle is won. The Goblins, outnumbered, fight to the last. The Hobs do terrible damage to my forces, but they do die. I watch them fall.

And when it's over, I meet Lady Rie. She says not a word, but walks out of her mansion, blood soaking the hem of her dress. Near the end I saw the doors open and her servants and personal guard rush out. They fought well, especially the bald man in armor.

She says not a word as she approaches me. I stand as the Mossbear whuffs and licks at an open cut on its side. Durene sits next to me, covered in blood, injured and alive. I walk over to Lady Rie, wondering what I should say.

She says nothing. As I approach, she drops to her knees in the muck and blood. I stare at her, and see the bald man and the young man in robes drop to their knees beside her. Lady Rie lowers her head. I watch her kneel, and sense the other soldiers around me doing the same. I look around.

The other soldiers kneel. A disparate group, soldiers and retired warriors, fathers and mothers and retired veterans from different homes. People who know this land, who rose up at a chance to defend it. It was nothing special, what I did. I proposed an alliance, I offered them a chance to fight as one. Anyone could have done it.

But I did it. And now they kneel to me. And some shout my name.

“Laken! Emperor Laken!”

“The Unseen Emperor!”

“The Emperor of Beasts!”

That last one is new. I glance backwards and sense the Mossbear licking Durene’s arm. I have to smile. It’s a story, and I’m a bad actor in it. But I’m slowly learning my lines. Because this is what I have to do. The road’s been set and I have to walk down it.

I am Laken, and it’s begun.

My empire.

[Emperor Level 19!]

[Skill – Imperial Levy obtained!]

[Skill – Empire: Darksky Riders obtained!]

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4.36 O

Of all the inns in Liscor, it was fair to say that the Tailless Thief run by Peslas was without dispute the best. No other inn had the same quality of food prepared by a [Cook] with [Advanced Cooking] and other Skills, or a high-level [Innkeeper], or the advantageous placement that Peslas' inn enjoyed. So Olesm would agree it was the best inn. Within Liscor, of course.

But he was growing sick of it. It wasn't just that Peslas was an intolerant old egghead, in Olesm's opinion, or that he missed another, younger, more intelligent and certainly more attractive [Innkeeper]. No, it was the drinking.

Peslas' inn served Drakes of all colors, and it was a Drake-themed establishment. That meant that spirits manufactured by Drakes were served almost exclusively, although it had to be said that Peslas had a very nice store of wines from around the world.

However, it was a Drake custom to have a shot of the fiery spirits they loved to brew before anything else. Even wine. The burning sensation added to the following experience of drinking wine, or so it was claimed.

Personally, Olesm didn't particularly enjoy the alcohol that had made Izril famous. The Drakes' signature Firebreath Whiskey, for instance, had the same reputation as the Drake species that made it. It was offensive, hard to tolerate in large doses, and usually the prelude to a fight if imbibed too heavily.

But it was a purely Drake drink, and so every time Wall Lord Ilvriss went drinking, Olesm would have to down at least a shot or two of it. He'd

grown to associate Peslas' inn with such drinking experiences, and so hated it.

“Another round, Peslas! And fill young Swifttail's glass. Don't be stingy! Everyone who drinks tonight does so on my coin. A Lord of the Wall from Salazar treats his brethren away from home with due respect! Never let it be said otherwise!”

Olesm groaned as he sat around the full table of Drakes and heard the cheer go up. It was predictable, of course; Ilvriss had been here last night, and the night before that, and Peslas' inn was packed.

“Here you are, sir. And for you, Olesm.”

Peslas himself bustled over with a refill. Olesm glumly watched as the glowing orange liquid was splashed generously into his mug. He turned and raised it to the Drake in armor sitting two places away from him.

“Your health, sir.”

“And to you, young Swifttail!”

Wall Lord Ilvriss raised his mug and drank down the fiery liquid, not stopping until he'd drained the mug to cheers from the officers, mages, and other members of his personal escort. Other Drakes, officials in the city or influential individuals, tried to emulate the Lord of the Wall with mixed results.

Olesm drank more slowly, gulping down the spirits and cursing Peslas for filling his mug so high. He got half of it down in the end and Ilvriss slapped his back, laughing heartily.

“A fine attempt! We'll have to teach you to drink properly while I'm still here, Olesm! A [Tactician] should be able to drink with his commanding officer, especially if he's to rise through the ranks. And I fully

expect you to in due time. A young prodigy at my table! It reminds me of when I was young.”

“You’re too kind.”

Olesm murmured and tried not to rub at his shoulder. He sat next to a high-level [Lieutenant] as Ilvriss began recounting one of the tales of when he’d been young. The other Drakes leaned forwards, laughing and interjecting comments or questions. Olesm tried to look interested and died a bit inside. It was always like this.

He hated being here, hated having to drink with the Wall Lord—just past *breakfast* for goodness sake! But, and here was the tricky bit, it was a real honor to be invited to such a gathering. Olesm wouldn’t have been allowed near this table if Ilvriss hadn’t requested that he sit with him. Yes, it was an honor. Because Ilvriss *liked* Olesm.

As the son he’d never had. Or perhaps as the student to whatever Ilvriss was mentoring. Maybe the Wall Lord was just bored, but after a few meetings with Liscor’s council, the Lord of the Wall had begun inviting Olesm to spend more time with him in Liscor. He seemed interested, pleased with Olesm’s ideas and what he termed ‘youthful invigorations’.

Ilvriss had taken Olesm under his tail, and as such, Olesm was often forced to go drinking with the Wall Lord and his personal retinue, or listen to long conversations about politics or the good days when the damned Ants weren’t here, Drakes were Drakes, and the Humans were nearly ready to crumble because they were cowardly fleshbags.

Despite the aforementioned honor of being invited, Olesm still might have dared to avoid such gatherings for his own health, if he weren’t under strict orders to the contrary.

It had been explained to him very thoroughly. Part of his job—rather, his *real* job—was to keep the Wall Lord happy while he was staying in

Liscor. Due to the presence of the Goblin Lord's armies, it was impossible to assure his safe return to his home city. In fact, Hawk, the lone Courier in Liscor, refused to try and make the trip.

Olesm personally thought that was a bit cowardly of the Rabbit Beastkin. Hawk was a Courier, and Olesm knew for a fact that his levels and Skills would probably allow him to survive any encounter on the roads, even if he ran straight into a raiding army of Goblins.

But that was Couriers for you. Some were cautious, and others were brave to the point of suicidal. Hawk was pragmatic. He'd seen both a Wall Lord and General Shivertail himself suffer defeat at the hand of the Goblin Lord, and after that, the destruction of two Drake armies. True, General Shivertail and Wall Lord Ilvriss hadn't been prepared and their armies had both been worn down from tearing each other to shreds, but the Courier didn't want to risk his ears.

So Ilvriss was stuck and antsy with it. He'd already gone out twice and slaughtered one of the Hollowstone Deceivers—the Rock Crabs as Erin termed them—and wiped out a number of Shield Spider nests. When he wasn't consulting with his various allies and contacts via [Message] spell or taking part in one of the innumerable strategy meetings going on in Liscor, he was here. Drinking.

The Drakes around the table roared with laughter as Ilvriss said something that might have been funny and Olesm tried to pretend he'd been listening. Inside he writhed in agony.

All Olesm wanted to do was go back to the Wandering Inn and sit there, drink something, and have a tasty snack while he played chess with Erin. He longed for that, those fleeting moments he kept in his memories. They had been simpler times.

But he couldn't now, although he wanted to. Olesm knew it would be impossible to get Ilvriss to shift his daily drinking session there because Erin didn't stock Firebreath Whiskey, she wasn't a Drake, and she was now hosting *Hobgoblins* in her inn. Olesm would have dearly loved to know what had possessed Erin, but the upshot was that he'd probably get Ilvriss to agree to chop off his own tail before the Drake agreed to drink under the same roof as a living Goblin.

What a mess. Olesm traced on the table with one of his claws, devoting one earhole to Ilvriss' account of his first battle. Erin really was in it this time. Watch Captain Zevara was furious and everyone was talking about how stupid she was for taking in Goblins. No one was willing to visit Erin's inn to get to Celum at the moment. Olesm sighed. He wondered if Erin would go out of business if she didn't kick the Goblins out. Why were they here, anyways?

More complications. It really had been better before, when Erin's inn was small and Olesm could walk in and have a chat with her without someone interrupting. But those days were gone, and Goblins were ruining everything for everyone.

And now the *army* was coming back, or at least, a small taskforce to help out with the Goblin situation. Olesm shuddered. He didn't have to be a [Tactician] to predict that there would be trouble if the Goblins were still in Erin's inn when they got here. They'd cause trouble.

Actually, they'd cause trouble even if the Goblins were nowhere to be seen. They always did every time they came back. And the commanders in Liscor's army made Zevara look relaxed. She *was* relaxed compared to how they did things.

“And there I was, broken sword in hand, staring down a damned [Blademaster] with an enchanted bastard sword of his own. I backed up and looked around but there was no help coming. Fortunately, I had been given

a ring by my mother for my first battle, so I raised it and twisted it—the very ring you see here—and...”

Everyone seemed to be hooked on Ilvriss. Olesm’s [Tactician] senses told him now was an ideal moment. He carefully lowered his mug and poured the rest of his drink onto the floorboards underneath the table. No one noticed; quaffing had been undertaken earlier this morning, and the room was already messy.

Drinking in the morning. Olesm shook his head. Half of the Drakes here would have to get to work. The rest, like Ilvriss, probably had livers made of steel because they’d be drinking and talking all day if no one interrupted them.

Then again, that was their right. They were high-level [Warriors], experienced soldiers, and veterans of numerous battles all. The Drakes who surrounded Ilvriss at all times could lead armies with the Lord of the Wall. Olesm felt small around them.

And yet, Ilvriss kept telling him he was a prodigy. Which was actually warranted, Olesm knew. He was a Level 27 [Tactician]. And he’d been Level 22 a few months ago. Olesm could hardly believe it. That kind of leveling was *insane* outside of wars. It was probably one of the reasons why Ilvriss had taken an interest in him.

But prodigy? It might be fair to say, but Olesm didn’t feel smart at all. He might be Level 27, but Erin had reached Level 30 in the same amount of time. From Level 1. From nothing. Remembering that, it wasn’t hard to stay humble. Meek.

Absently, forgetting he’d already gotten rid of his drink, Olesm raised his mug to his lips. Ilvriss noticed the Drake blinking into his mug and raised his voice.

“What’s this? Done so soon? Good lad! Another round for young Swifttail!”

“Oh, no, please—”

If he had to down another mouthful, Olesm thought he might actually puke. He waved a hand and Ilvriss laughed again.

“Don’t be so modest, young Swifttail! We’re drinking in part to celebrate *you*! A Level 27 [Tactician]? When I was your age I hadn’t reached Level 20! Soon you’ll be a [Strategist], and when you are, you’ll truly be a person of influence in your own right.”

He waved a hand expansively at the two [Strategists] that were part of his own retinue. Olesm had met the male and female Drakes—they were a married couple—and he ducked his head at them, noting their approving smiles. They treated him like a son as well.

“You’re too kind, Wall Lord.”

“Am I? Am I? Perhaps. But if I am, it is only because I recognize talent. A [Strategist] may be essential to every army, but they are hardly common! You could join any army with that class. I know you’re a citizen of Liscor, but it would be a shame to waste your abilities in a mercenary army, even one as acclaimed as Liscor’s. When the day comes that you reach that level, I hope you might consider moving to Salazsar. The Walled Cities have need of fresh minds like yours.”

This was beyond a compliment. Olesm went red, and the table of Drakes laughed. He stammered, trying to change the subject.

“I uh, I’m not sure I’m that close. Is [Strategist] that simple of an upgrade from [Tactician]? I thought it was a Level 40 class, at least.”

That was a flat lie, but Ilvriss took the bait.

“Level 40? Hah! What prank have you fallen for? [Strategists] are Level 30. Or...I’ve heard they can be lower if you combine a military rank with the [Tactician] class. A Level 20 [Tactician] and a Level 10 [Sergeant] or something, you understand? But that’s a shortcut. A diluted achievement. Young Olesm’s *pure*.”

There was a slur in his voice. He was already drunk. Another Drake, an obsequious [Merchant] who always flattered Ilvriss, raised his own mug.

“Hah, yes! A pure young Drake. We should be careful we don’t sully his youth before he gets a taste for the world. Young Olesm here needs to taste more of life’s pleasures before he enters politics, Wall Lord. More drink, more time in battle...and in bed, I should wager!”

Ilvriss howled with laughter and banged on the table with the others. Olesm rolled his eyes and twitched his tail irritably. There had been a lot of talk like that. Olesm hadn’t ever taken part in a war, so to all the veterans he was fresh-tailed, and they made jokes at his expense.

It was time to go. Olesm knew he shouldn’t play this card too often, but he had a job to do today so it was a legitimate card. He pushed back his chair, bowing apologetically to Ilvriss.

“Much as I’d love to drink, I’m afraid I really do have pressing obligations, Wall Lord.”

“Ah. I’d forgotten.”

Ilvriss paused and scowled, as if the bright sunlight streaming into the room were an afterthought. He glanced at Olesm impatiently.

“Can’t you postpone whatever needs doing?”

Olesm made an apologetic face.

“I’m afraid not, sir. I...it would be wrong of me to abandon my post, no matter how honored I am to be here. I must stick to my duty.”

Something changed in Ilvriss’ face as he listened to Olesm’s careful words. Quick as lightning his mirth disappeared. He lowered his mug, and Olesm saw the other Drakes around him quiet down and watch the Wall Lord warily.

“Duty? Ah, if duty calls one must obey, mustn’t they? But be cautious, young Olesm. Duty is a harsh mistress and she asks much. Death walks with you, and sometimes it cannot be avoided. Even if you had known—even if—”

He broke off and looked into his mug, all the mirth of a moment ago lost. Olesm exchanged glances with the other Drakes sitting around the table.

Wall Lord Ilvriss had been maudlin recently. Ever since the battle with Regrika Blackpaw and the other Gold-rank traitor, Imenet. He was prone to snapping at others, drinking to excess, and fits of melancholy—not too different from his usual self, in other words. But the sadness was new.

Someone had to bring him back to his good spirits. This time it was Peslas. The [Innkeeper] hurried over with a hot plate of grilled fish and a mug of wine.

“Yes, to duty! Young Olesm must go, but surely you have more tales to tell, Wall Lord? I’d be grateful to hear more—it’s not often a legend sits in my inn!”

Ilvriss brightened a bit as he saw the food. He accepted both plate and mug and nodded as all eyes fell on him again.

“Well, I suppose if I must—go, Olesm. I’ll remain here. As for stories, if that’s what you want Peslas, I have one about my finest subordinate. Periss.

She was—a warrior and leader beyond repute. I remember the day I first met her. She'd downed a Wyvern. By herself! I was in my tent and I heard about a patrol that had been ambushed by monsters, so I rushed out and saw her there..."

Olesm backed out of the inn, grateful for the reprieve. Besides, he really did have a job to do. He was Liscor's dedicated [Tactician], after all. Every Drake city needed one and Olesm worked hard at his job. True, there wasn't always work to do, but recently there had been a lot. So much so that he'd only gotten to the issue of the dungeon today. Or more specifically, what lived in the dungeon.

Shield Spiders. Crypt Worms. Various undead. Enchanted suits of armor, Bog Wraiths, a trap full of Face-Eater Moths, giant infested slugs, the Children, the list went on. Olesm was privy to almost every report that went to Watch Captain Zevara and other members of the Council and so he knew that Liscor's dungeon was host to a huge variety of very nasty monsters.

Some were documented, others were variations on known threats. It was an adventurer's job to handle them, and Olesm's only input into the situation with the dungeon was to consult with Zevara about containing any threats that escaped from either the Dungeon's official entrance or the rift in the snow. Plans were already being made to set up a more permanent set of fortifications around both.

However, there was one variety of monster that had been spotted by the teams going in and out of the dungeon's rift that was...concerning. Among the monsters that roamed the maze of trapped tunnels were groups of

Goblins and strange, Gnoll-like monsters who used weapons and fought with brutal efficiency.

The first group to encounter them (and survive), Vuliel Drae, had brought back several heads. Olesm had inspected them and they certainly looked similar to a Gnoll's. However, the heads were far larger, sported vicious canines and apparently came from bodies far bigger than any Gnoll had a right to be.

The Adventurer's Guild hadn't been able to identify the monster when they'd sent the image of the head to other guilds for analysis. However, several of the older Gnolls had reacted strongly to the heads but refused to say what they'd recognized. Thus, it fell to Olesm to tactfully ask what these not-Gnolls were about.

He decided to go to Krshia, since he knew her the best and she was one of the leaders of the Gnolls in the city. Olesm rubbed at his head and swerved down the street, greeting Drakes and Gnolls he knew as they waved to him. The Gnolls sniffed and remarked about drinking so early; Olesm grunted about Ilvriss and they only laughed.

The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] wasn't at her stall today, which was unusual. Olesm had to ask where her apartment was. Thankfully two other Gnolls at the small marketplace were able to direct him.

They knew him, of course; Gnolls were very conscious of figures of authority and Olesm had made it a point to consult with the Gnolls who represented the unofficial figures of authority in Liscor. It was a shame none of them had a place on the Council; a few Gnolls might nicely balance out the idiots who thought with their tails.

Unlike Erin, Olesm didn't regularly visit Krshia. In fact, he'd been staying away from both Erin and the Gnoll recently. Olesm still felt guilty about telling Regrika about Ryoka. That had led to Brunkr's death, and, it

seemed, Ryoka's disappearance. He knew it was impossible to have known that Regrika Blackpaw, the famed Named Adventurer, was a murderer, but still. Olesm hesitated in front of Krshia's door for several minutes before he reluctantly knocked.

The apartment was silent for a long time. Long enough that Olesm was turning to go when he heard someone shuffling towards the door. He waited, and Krshia slowly pulled the door open. She blinked at him and he stared up at her.

"Um, good morning, Krshia. Are you well?"

She didn't look well. The Gnoll was barely dressed and she had bleary eyes and disheveled fur. She looked terrible, in short. Olesm cleared his throat as he glanced into her apartment. It too was a mess.

"I ah—I'm terribly sorry to bother you, but I was hoping I could speak to you as a representative of the Gnolls in Liscor. I wouldn't want to intrude if you're occupied, however..."

Only now did he realize he might be intruding on her grief. But Krshia blinked at Olesm and seemed to wake up a bit. She shook herself, and then nodded.

"I—hrr. Yes. As a representative, you said? What is this about? Come in—let me freshen myself and put on tea."

She invited him in. Olesm was hesitant at first, but Krshia seemed glad of the company. She rushed about, clearing a space on the sofa—it looked like she'd been sleeping there—and putting on some of the spicy Gnoll tea. When she sat across from him and offered him some sliced raw meat, she looked a lot more awake than before, and curious, too.

"It is not often that Olesm Swifttail comes to my residence on official business, yes? That is what this is, yes? Has the Council decided something,

or is this more informal?”

“It’s...formal, but not related to any decision the city has made.”

Olesm carefully chewed at the meat and sipped from his cup, grateful for both after drinking. Krshia nodded encouragingly and he went on, watching her expression carefully.

“I believe you have heard about the reports from the dungeon, Miss Krshia? Part of my job involves identifying monsters who may be a threat to the city, particularly if they are unknown. And a recent team that went into the dungeon recovered several, uh, heads of a strange creature they claimed was fighting in tandem with Goblins. They um...”

The Gnoll’s forehead wrinkled and Olesm broke off. Krshia hummed to herself and nodded. Now there was a sharpness to her eyes that Olesm recognized with relief.

“Ah. I see what this is about. You wish to ask about these creatures which resemble my people so much.”

“Yes. Yes, the other Gnolls wouldn’t talk about it. However, if these—these creatures are a threat, or worse, are related to Gnolls—”

“They are. Both threat and related. It is an uncomfortable topic among my people, Olesm. Many of the young do not know of these...things. But I saw one of the heads and yes, I do know what they are.”

“Ah. Would you be willing to share your information? I promise, we only need tactical data, not anything—”

Olesm broke off delicately and Krshia shrugged.

“Tactical data? I do not know if it will help, but the story is only uncomfortable, not taboo. I will relate it to you. If you have time?

“Please, I would be most grateful.”

Krshia nodded with a slight smile. She sipped at her cup and chewed on more slices of meat. Her stomach rumbled a bit and Olesm wondered if she'd had breakfast. He took another slice, chewing appreciatively. Gnolls liked their food to be eaten when they offered it. A full bowl of snacks after a discussion was a disappointment.

"Hrr. Yes. Where to begin? I think we must delve into history first, Olesm. You see, the origin of these creatures that resemble us goes back to when the continent was first inhabited by our peoples. Drakes and Gnolls."

The Drake paused as he reached for another slice of meat. He stared at Krshia.

"That long ago? But that's *ancient* history. Thousands of years old!"

Krshia nodded. She smiled a bit as Olesm stared at her.

"Yes. Is it surprising I would know tales from back then? It is true few books survive so long, enchanted or not, but history is told through our tribes differently from the Drakes. It is spoken, passed from Gnoll to Gnoll. And we remember things in ways you do not. For instance, long ago it was said that Izril was not known as the home of Drakes and Gnolls, but as the home of Dragons."

"Our Ancestors."

Olesm murmured respectfully and with a hint of longing. He had never seen a Dragon before, only heard rumors. One in Terandria for instance, that preyed on livestock. But Ancestors, *real* Drake Ancestors, were supposed to be wise and cunning, full of magic and wonders. And greed, of course. That's where Drakes got it from. Krshia nodded. She sniffed and chewed on a bit of the raw meat in the bowl. She clearly had no longing for the past.

“Yes. I have heard what Drakes say. But that is not the Gnoll experience, no. Our people remember a time when Dragons ruled and their descendants, Drakes, built vast and impregnable cities to shield themselves from war with their elders. Dragons and Drakes fought, but both preyed on a common species. Gnolls. We were food for Dragons. Drakes too. Our peoples lived in terror of the skies.”

Olesm shifted uncomfortably. Krshia smiled gently.

“It is not your fault for the past Olesm, yes? Regardless, in order to survive, it is said that we Gnolls dug deep and learned how to hide. We found refuge in caverns, lived underground. And down there, some of us... changed.”

“Changed? How?”

The Gnoll paused as she sat across from Olesm. She looked uncomfortable, but she shook her head and shrugged in reply to his question.

“It was dark in the ground, Olesm. Dark, or so the stories say, and we Gnolls are not meant to dig so deep. We spent years, decades, in hiding. Longer, I think, but the stories are not clear. In any case, we spent so long down there that some of us went mad from the deepness of it. Mad and wild. Their bodies changed as they forgot the ways of civilization—and we Gnolls are civilized, for all that you call us tribal creatures.”

“I have never thought so.”

“Hrm. No? Well, others say it and there is some truth to it. But these other Gnolls lost those hints of civilization. They became bestial, more like monsters than people, yes? That is when Gnollkind split. In the darkness, one group remained Gnolls and others became—not.”

Olesm stared at Krshia.

“How is that possible? You’re saying Gnolls as a species changed? How?”

She shrugged.

“It was only some. As to how, perhaps it was magic, or perhaps it was just a difference in what they ate. Or what they did.”

“I don’t follow.”

“The others, the not-Gnolls. They longed for the light, yes? That longing can be a terrible thing. They lost their minds in the darkness. Became as savage as the things that dug around them. Ate and killed, and gained strength for it. They gave up their levels, Olesm.”

Memory stirred. Olesm remembered hearing about Ryoka’s refusal to level. But he still couldn’t believe it.

“Impossible. As a people? You mean...”

The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] nodded.

“It was a trade, I think. A curse willingly taken, or—or something else. These not-Gnolls turned their backs on what made them Gnolls to become stronger. They obtained powerful forms, dangerous abilities...but at a price. They lost their ability to level in exchange for bodies like steel, strength beyond other Gnolls. But they lost their minds, became warlike, hungry only for blood and flesh. Again, at a price. It was said of these Gnolls that they underwent strange changes in the moonlight. Only during the full moon would they regain any measure of sanity.”

Olesm tried to imagine such creatures. It wasn’t hard, actually. Take away the intelligence of a Gnoll, replace it with a primitive mind and make them stronger—he shuddered as he imagined a tribe of them living deep in the darkness.

“I take it that the other Gnolls who didn’t change didn’t like these new Gnolls?”

Krshia nodded grimly.

“They began to hunt us. As if we were not their family. And so we fought back. In the darkness, Gnoll fought not-Gnoll and the difference between us became great. In time, the others were no longer Gnolls at all, but different. We called them Raskghar and they are our enemies.”

“Were your enemies, you mean.”

The [Shopkeeper] shook her head.

“Are. We thought them wiped out long ago, but if they remain, they are our foes yet.”

“But hold on, you said that was thousands of years ago. These Raskghar—these cave Gnolls are only in Liscor, in a dungeon we just discovered. Doesn’t that change—”

Krshia was shaking her head again and again. She fixed Olesm with one steady eye as she sipped from her cup.

“We declared war on them, Olesm. As a people. Gnoll tribes may war and make peace as they choose, of course, but when we make war, it is as a species. We do not lay down our arms until all tribes have agreed. So. If these creatures do live below Liscor, then we are *still* at war with them. Time is meaningless to our feud.”

“But—”

Olesm forced himself to break off. He was dealing with a different culture here, a different species. Krshia eyed Olesm and relented a bit.

“Recall that during the war, our people fought without peace against yours for hundreds of years, Olesm. The war did not end, though both our

species suffered greatly. When we emerged from the ground we declared war on the Drakes, now that the Dragons had lost their hold on the continent. We declared it as a people, and such was the bloodshed that there has not been a greater loss of life since, not even from the Antinium.”

Olesm nodded. The war. Of course he knew that bit of history. People, mostly Humans, liked to talk about the Antinium Wars as the great wars of the century, but to the Drakes and Gnolls, there would be only one great war. It was *the* war. The war between their species.

“As I recall, the Gnolls were present throughout the continent but strongest in the north. They destroyed many of the Walled Cities built there and several in the south. There were countless deaths on both sides. However...it may be an unpopular opinion, but my analysis of the histories makes me believe the Gnolls were winning during that time.”

Krshia blinked. She seemed surprised, which was unusual for her.

“Oh? What makes you say this?”

Olesm shrugged self-consciously.

“It’s nothing conclusive. I’ve hardly done an in-depth study of the history, but it’s just that Drakes were famous for the cities we built. We kept most of our populations behind the Walled Cities—we still do, only in smaller and more numerous cities. But when we were fighting in the war, the Gnolls were slowly destroying our homes, breaking down the enchanted walls one by one. [Shamans], leading armies of hundreds of thousands, warrior-kings, bloody battles...we both lost, but Gnolls could always regroup and live anywhere on the continent. While we Drakes were losing our homes. So I think we were losing.”

He paused. Krshia was blinking at him and he could tell she had something to say. She sipped deeply from her cup and then refilled it. And his. Krshia smiled at Olesm.

“Hrr. Rarely have I met a Drake who is willing to say such things. Your people dislike admitting defeat. But that is the opinion of we Gnolls. We were winning. For that truth Olesm Swifttail, I thank you.”

She bowed her head slightly and Olesm felt his scales changing color.

“It’s nothing. Just facts. It’s just the facts, Miss Krshia. And as you said, the war was terrible for both sides regardless of who was winning.”

Krshia sighed, reluctantly agreeing.

“But of course. It matters little, yes? The Humans took half the continent while we squabbled. The Five Families destroyed the last of the Walled Cities in the north and drove both our peoples south, past the High Passes.”

Olesm nodded gravely.

“The Gnoll tribes fought to the last for their lands, if I recall. Your people suffered a terrible loss.”

“One we have still not recovered from. That is why we as a people sued for peace with the Humans. Why we do not march north each year with your kind. Oh, some city-born fight in your armies, but the Gnolls will not die. Our tribes grow and we replenish, but our people are a fraction of what they were.”

“True, but the Gnoll populations have been on the rise historically. I remember seeing some figures...the Antinium Wars barely halted your growth. Why, if your population keeps rising the way some of our [Strategists] and [Historians] are suggesting...”

The Drake was searching through his notepad. He paused as a thought struck him and peered suspiciously at Krshia.

“Miss Silverfang? Exactly how many tribes would you say are formed every year? And how many of those tribes double or triple their numbers every decade?”

Krshia’s eyes twinkled. The Gnoll averted her gaze and sipped at her tea thoughtfully. She spoke cattily, her ears flicking back and forth as she peeked at Olesm’s face.

“If my people do have plans that involve Drakes or Humans, it would only be in a few more generations, yes? Numbers matter. And I...hope it would be peaceful. All we wish to do is reclaim our old lands. If that means living next to Humans, so be it.”

“I see.”

Olesm filed that information away for later. He cleared his throat.

“Thank you for the history. It seems these Raskghar are a threat, both to your people and in general. I don’t think the Council or the Adventurer’s Guild would argue that point. May I ask what you know about their combat abilities? If they don’t level that’s one relief, but just how strong are they in general?”

The Gnoll pondered the question for a while.

“Hrr. It is too long ago for specifics to be passed down, but I would imagine a single one of these Raskghar would be a match for a Silver-rank adventurer. They were said to be strong, immune to pain, and have hides that were proof against iron. But those are legends. I imagine the truth is that they are simply stronger. Primal, primitive Gnolls who cannot level but have more strength than our kind.”

“I see. Well, thank you for your time, Krshia. I will have to relay that to the Adventurer’s Guild. I think these Raskghar would be classified as a threat similar to Hobgoblins. Unless you disagree?”

Krshia was shaking her head. She looked serious as she pointed a finger of her paw at Olesm.

“Not at all. Hobgoblins are dangerous, like the ones in Erin’s inn, yes? But they are a danger because of numbers as much as their skill. Raskghar are brutes. They may be stronger naturally than Hobs, but they lack levels so they would fall behind in strength. What makes them dangerous is that they are *born* to the darkness, Olesm. They hunt in places without light. They are not warriors, they are predators. They track their prey and ambush them. That is the danger.”

Not warriors, but creatures adapted perfectly to an environment with mazes and traps. Ambush specialists. Olesm nodded.

“I’ll emphasize that in my report and make sure the adventurers know to be careful. Thank you very much, Miss Krshia.”

“You are welcome, Olesm.”

The Gnoll smiled at Olesm and he sensed that she was in better spirits than when she’d first opened the door. Krshia eyed the scraps of meat left in her bowl and stood up.

“I have enjoyed your company. But you do not need to leave right away, yes? Sit. Let us talk. I have heard rumors about Erin, although I have not seen her in days. And I have more snacks—let us have some breadsticks. I have some honey...I would not like to waste it. And there is more tea.”

Olesm smiled at Krshia. He had not missed the shield and sword carefully propped up against one wall, or the way Krshia kept looking around. The apartment was empty. There was a vacancy in it. For a while he could fill it.

“I would be honored to sit, of course. Please, tell me, what do you think about this issue of the Goblin Lord?”

It was a good two hours more before Olesm could leave Krshia's home, but he considered that time well spent by comparison. Olesm first waddled over to one of the public toilets and relieved himself of half a pot's worth of tea. Then he walked down the street. The snow had completely melted in Liscor, but it was still chilly outside. Olesm tugged at the cloak he wore and fished at his belt pouch.

He pulled out a pad of tightly bound pieces of paper; a luxury compared to parchment, but one the city paid him for. He also had an enchanted quill that drew ink from a pot without him needing to dip it, a very useful invention. Olesm walked and wrote, muttering to himself as he did.

"Gnoll breeding strategy. Talk to Gen. Shivertail or Wall Lord?
Concerns—future generations."

Olesm paused as he stared at the cramped handwriting. Then he sighed and scribbled over the words. No, not a good idea. This was him being a hoarder, thinking too narrowly. Gnolls were not the enemy. Come to that, Humans weren't the enemy. Not anymore. They'd lived here for generations. Didn't that mean they had a place? They weren't the ones who'd razed Drake cities and put thousands to the sword, no matter what the elders said.

No, the real enemy was the Antinium. And Olesm wasn't sure if all of them were the enemy. Sighing, Olesm crossed out the words a few more times and jotted down the notes about the Raskghar.

"Did I spell that right? Oh well. It's good enough. Now..."

Olesm hesitated and looked around, tail twitching as he stood in the street. He *could* go back to the inn and file the report later, but that would

mean drinking. On the other claw, Olesm was fairly sure that Selys was at the desk in the Adventurer's Guild at the moment and he could probably spend hours filing a report in person and chatting with her. Also, there was that thing that had been nagging at Olesm for days. Maybe he could resolve it today?

It certainly beat drinking. So Olesm turned around in the street, waved to one of his chess-buddies, and hurried over to the Adventurer's Guild. It was packed. As usual. Humans, Gnolls, and Drakes were all waiting in lines, or sitting out of the cold and talking.

Olesm was pleased that there was less of a crush than before; while it was true the adventurers were here for the dungeon, Erin's door to Celum had allowed a lot of the pressure to be taken off of Liscor's guild. Now adventurers were saturating the region around Liscor, rather than all crammed into the one city and causing trouble exclusively here.

Still, he had to wait in line. There were four counters open, and each [Receptionist] was busy. Olesm spotted Selys and saw there was only one person in front of him. He hurried over and then recognized the Human arguing at the desk.

“—and furthermore, I object to your characterization of my talents. I am offering you an equitable, nay, *charitable* solution to an unresolved crisis in your city, and you are not considering it, let alone relaying my request to your Guildmaster!”

Pisces put his hands flat on the counter and glared at Selys. The Drake [Receptionist] glared back and leaned over the desk so that Pisces had to lean back or receive a slow head butt. Her tail thrashed behind the counter.

“First off, it's Guild*mistress*. My Grandmother's in charge and she doesn't like [Necromancers]. In fact, she likes them less than I do.

Furthermore, I can't authorize putting a dangerous monster in the sewers —”

“*Dangerous?*”

Pisces spluttered. He was receiving a lot of unfriendly looks from around the room Olesm noted, but he was focused on Selys. He leaned forwards until he was nose-to-snout with Selys.

“It would be under my control at all times. True, it would be remotely, but it would operate under precise instructions—”

“Oh? Like the ones you gave Toren before he abandoned Erin and went off and killed a bunch of people?”

The [Necromancer]’s teeth ground together audibly.

“That was a separate case with an autonomous creation with *free will*, not—”

“You have your answer. *Next!* Oh, hi there Olesm! How can I help you?”

Pisces was incandescent with fury, but Selys calmly pushed him aside and smiled sweetly at Olesm. He smiled back. Suddenly, Olesm recalled why he hadn’t ever really talked to Selys before they’d both known Erin.

She was a social personality, always talking, but she had an *edge* when she got mad. Selys and Olesm ran in different circles. Olesm coughed and stepped forwards, tail twitching apologetically as Pisces glared at both of them.

“Hello, Selys. I’m actually here to deliver a report about those Gnoll-like monsters that were found in the dungeon. I’ve investigated the matter and they’re a primitive offshoot of the Gnoll species. Some kind of throwback or...well, they’re clearly dangerous and they’re adapted for the

darkness. The Gnolls hate them and I have a few details on how they might fight.”

“Really? Freakish Gnoll offshoots, huh?”

Selys’ nonexistent eyebrows rose. She glanced out the window and made a face.

“It sounds important, and I’d love to hear about them, but I’m nearly done with my shift, Olesm. This jerk—”

She pointed towards Pisces with her tail and the [Necromancer] glowered. He still hadn’t moved away and was making Olesm uncomfortable.

“—took up a lot of my time and I’m actually meeting with Erin right after this. Can I call over my replacement and have her get all the details? Or better yet, can you send a report through all those official channels? It’s not that we can’t do it, it’s just that we’re a bit overworked, you know?”

She made a face. Olesm floundered, and then nodded. That wasn’t what he wanted, but what could he say?

“Of course. That would be fine.”

“Cool. Oh, and so I can mention it to Erin—what are these not-Gnolls called?”

“Raskghar. I think.”

“Got it. Hey, Maviss! Can you take over? Thanks!”

Selys walked out from behind the counter and another Drake took her place. Maviss, a Drake with light pinkish-red scales, smiled sweetly at Olesm. A bit too sweetly. Selys winked at her friend and Olesm edged back from the counter.

“Ah. Ahem. Selys tells me you’re very busy, so I’ll file that report and submit it tonight—”

“Are you sure? I’m sure I could write it all down if you want.”

Pisces was trying to chase after Selys until she tripped him up with her tail. He stood up to laughter, flushing with anger, and Olesm shook his head. He cleared his throat and then lowered his voice. There was one other reason why he’d come to the Adventurer’s Guild, and that was to follow up on a hunch.

“I wonder, Miss Maviss, whether your guild has the records of the recent expedition into the crypt by four Silver-ranked adventuring teams? The one with the attacking undead, led by the creature known as Skinner?”

Maviss’ smile vanished. She nodded. Everyone in Liscor remembered that night of horrors.

“We have lots of files. But don’t you get all of them as a [Tactician]?”

He shook his head.

“All the ones about the attack, of course, testimonies, statements from the [Guardsmen]...but when the adventurers were uh, recovered and their remains were counted, that report got sent to your guild. If the city kept a copy, it’s lost somewhere. I was hoping I could see it. I’m especially interested in what the [Guardsmen] found. The possessions of the deceased adventuring teams that were confiscated and so on.”

The [Receptionist] thought about that and then nodded.

“I can get that for you. It might take a bit. Why don’t you wait here? Unless you’d like to help?”

She winked at Olesm. He blushed.

“I, uh, no, I’m sorry. I have uh, a lot of pressing engagements. With the Wall Lord. I do apologize.”

“Oh. Alright then.”

Looking disappointed, Maviss sighed and walked into one of the back rooms where files were kept. Formal documentation might not exist in Human guilds, but Drakes were sticklers for reports and filing, so Olesm was sure a copy of the report he needed was back there. He turned, intending to take a seat while Maviss searched, and jumped as he saw Pisces standing behind him.

“A report from the events surrounding the crypt and the attack of the undead horde? Why would you be interested in that?”

The [Necromancer] eyed Olesm, arms folded, completely unapologetic about eavesdropping. Olesm coughed.

“Good morning, uh, Pisces.”

“Olesm.”

The [Mage] and [Tactician] stared at each other. Neither quite knew what to say. True, they’d met and played games of chess against each other, but that was because both of them knew Erin. They weren’t exactly acquaintances; neither one could remember really having a long conversation together.

Olesm shifted.

“I uh, I’m following up a discrepancy with the reports, which is why I requested them.”

“Ah. I see. And what is it you have uncovered?”

“Confidential, I’m afraid. City business. What were you asking Selys about? It seemed important.”

“Confidential.”

Pisces’ tone was acerbic as he looked down his nose at Olesm. Pisces’ gaze flicked to the Drake’s face, to his tail, and then to the notepad Olesm was still holding. The Drake hurriedly put that away. He didn’t like how Pisces always seemed so...so *perceptive* about things. For one thing, the [Necromancer] was one of the few Humans who watched Drakes’ tails for their reactions. Olesm kept his very still and raised his voice casually.

“How’s uh, the adventuring business? Doing a lot of fun...killing monsters? How’s Ceria doing?”

He winced. He hadn’t meant to blurt that out. Even if he had meant to ask. Pisces blinked. He studied Olesm and the Drake just knew he was recalling Olesm’s very brief fling with Ceria and the moment when she’d rejected his request to join the Horns of Hammerad. The memory made Olesm want to gnaw on his tail.

The [Necromancer] betrayed none of what he was thinking, though. He lifted his shoulder fractionally and sniffed.

“We have been undertaking mundane requests of little worth as of late. There are few worthwhile tasks to complete as I’m sure you’re aware. Oversaturation of adventurers...I believe Springwalker and the others are resting in the inn. They were most upset after our last mission.”

Olesm’s heart began to pound.

“Why? Is she—I mean, is everyone alright? I haven’t visited the inn in a while.”

Again, Pisces sniffed.

“Nothing damaging. Rather, we had accepted a rather odious task to clear an infested cave of vermin. The mission was hardly dangerous. Physically, that is.”

“Vermin?”

“Yes. An infested cave a few miles from Liscor. It was filled with roaches. Cockroaches. About ten thousand of them. Our task was to eliminate their nest and as many as possible. There were...complications.”

Pisces brushed at his robes. Only now did Olesm look down and notice several smears on the robes. They were enchanted to resist staining and dirt, of course, but the liquid on the robes was sticky. There were black bits of shell and wing and a few legs—Olesm’s tail *twitched* and Pisces grinned.

“Ice magic is futile against those kinds of roaches. We had to burn them. Unfortunately, there were larger variants with nasty bites and they swarmed us. Well, I say ‘us’ when I mean my other three companions. They got into Yvlon’s armor and onto Ceria...Ksmvr was most helpful in eating them. I believe he and Ceria consider the roaches as snacks and were more offended by the bites than anything else.”

He seemed amused by Olesm’s reaction. Pisces looked around the room, meeting a few gazes before they quickly averted. He shook his head and sniffed a third time.

“I was intending to do more work today, but it seems my presence is unwelcome here.”

That was an understatement. Adventurers watched Pisces with folded arms. Some turned their backs to him. One made a gesture. Olesm winced. He knew [Necromancers] were unpopular in Liscor and the rest of the continent—well, most of the world, really—for good reason, but Pisces’ attitude seemed to exacerbate the issue.

“I got the report! Olesm, I have them and—oh.”

Maviss returned, holding a sheaf of parchment and stopped when she saw Pisces. He looked at her and she hurriedly shoved the file into Olesm’s

hand before retreating behind the counter. Olesm paged through the report.

“It seems like everything I need. Miss Maviss, can I return this at a later date?”

“Absolutely! Uh—can I help you?”

Maviss stared at Pisces, tail twitching nervously. He looked at Olesm and then at her and shook his head.

“Not in the slightest, I would imagine.”

He turned. Olesm looked at Maviss.

“Thank you for the files. I have to be going.”

“Oh. Wouldn’t you like to stay for—”

The Drake hurried away and out of the guild. Olesm walked quickly, pausing to greet an adventurer he knew, and then hurried down the street. He wanted to open the report in his apartment, but realized someone was striding along in the same direction as him, practically at the same speed.

Olesm and Pisces halted in the street, staring at each other as Drakes and Gnolls walked around them. Pisces frowned at Olesm. Olesm scowled at Pisces.

“Why are you following me?”

Pisces sniffed.

“I am not. It would appear we were moving in the same direction purely by happenstance. That is known as coincidence.”

He turned. Olesm stuck his tongue out at his back and heard a giggle. He turned, and then his scales turned bright red as he saw Drassi and a few female Drakes he recognized gossiping together. They waved and Olesm waved back before covering his face with one claw.

Pisces glanced at the Drakes, and noticed one of the [Guardsmen] on patrol giving Olesm a nod. The same [Guardsmen] spat as he passed by Pisces. The mage's voice was acerbic.

"It seems you are well beloved in this city, Mister Swifttail."

Olesm nodded. He felt a bit embarrassed, actually, given how people were treating Pisces.

"I get to know a lot of people in my job. It uh, seems like you're not well loved here."

The [Necromancer] shrugged.

"My reputation as a [Necromancer] precedes me. Too, there are my past crimes."

Olesm recalled the incident with the monster terrorizing innocent villagers out of food and coin. He scowled.

"Yes. That. But I think people might still treat you better if you made an effort."

Pisces was turning to go. He looked over his shoulder and raised his eyebrows.

"Why should I? Their opinions are set in stone. Besides, my isolation is a product of my achievements and who I am. Talent is lonely. I do not need friends or adulation. Success is its own reward."

His words stung Olesm's scales like nettles. And yet, at the same time Olesm had an instinctive sense that Pisces was lying through his teeth. He didn't have a truth detection Skill, but the Drake still sensed it. And...
talent?

Olesm thought about Ilvriss praising him, and the shame and mixed emotions he felt. Whereas Pisces practically shouted his own arrogance.

That lit a fire under his tail. He snapped at Pisces.

“You seem to have an inflated opinion of your abilities.”

Pisces smirked.

“Accurately judging my own worth is not hubris. If others fail to comprehend my worth, that is their failing. Not mine.”

“Oh yeah? Well—well, what if you’re wrong?”

Snappy retorts were the specialty of Selys, not him. Olesm felt his scales flush and Pisces gave him a condescending look that was worse than a reply. Olesm lashed his tail against the paving stones.

“Okay then. If you’re so special, why are you lowering yourself to adventuring with others? Unless you’re not talented enough to do things by yourself?”

The mage’s eyes narrowed. He took a moment to respond, and his coolness infuriated Olesm even more.

“Pragmatism, of course. And perhaps a bit of—nostalgia. Regardless, my status as an adventurer is a career decision. The true mystery is why *you* aren’t an adventurer. You seem enamored with the profession, not to mention a certain individual. Why not pursue such interests?”

The words hit Olesm right in the heart this time. A critical hit. He stared at Pisces, feeling his fury rising. He spat.

“*I* wasn’t invited. I asked, as you recall.”

“Indeed I do. Hm. If a rejection was enough to stop you, then perhaps it was wise of you not to choose to be an adventurer after all. Words may burn, but they are a paltry force compared to claws and magic. If you cannot weather rejection, combat would certainly prove your undoing.”

The arch look. The burning words. Olesm opened his mouth and lifted the report about the dead adventurers.

“At least I was brave enough to go with them the first time! Where were you? Too cowardly to join them? I know Ceria asked you—why come crawling to her later when you rejected her once?”

Pisces’ eyes narrowed dangerously. He opened his mouth and Olesm balled his claws into fists. Before he or Olesm could say anything else, both heard a voice calling Olesm’s name.

“Olesm! Olesm Swifttail! I have a delivery for you!”

The Drake turned his head. His eyes widened.

“Hawk?”

The Rabbitman was striding down the street, moving twice as fast as anyone else. As usual, Hawk appeared to be practically vibrating with energy. In the cold weather he’d left his muscular abdomen exposed and he seemed immune to the chill. Olesm wondered if he’d had any of Erin’s Corusdeer Soup.

The Courier halted in front of Olesm and opened a pouch on his belt. It must have been a belt pouch of holding, because he pulled out several objects before he came up with a very thick sealed envelope. Olesm stared at it. If Hawk was delivering it, the letter had to be sent by Courier. Or was Hawk doing City Runner deliveries?

“What’s this about, Hawk?”

The Rabbit Tribe Beastkin offered Olesm the letter.

“I’ve got a message for you, Olesm. What else? It’s a pretty lucrative delivery for me; a simple package. I got it from Invril—a quick run, even

with the Corusdeer stampede I had to dodge. Here, just state to me on this truth stone that you are Olesm Swifttail and—”

“Wait, what? But I—I haven’t been expecting any deliveries! And this looks expensive!”

Hawk nodded.

“Sure is. I can’t tell you the specifics—Runner’s confidentiality and all that, but I think this came from First Landing. Which means it’s from another continent.”

Olesm blinked.

“Another *continent*?”

Pisces was staring intently at the letter and at Hawk. The Courier eyed him, but said nothing. He was all business as he offered Olesm the various tools Couriers used to prove their deliveries had occurred, and then nodded.

“Looks good. Here you go.”

He handed Olesm the letter. It was thick and the paper looked very costly. Olesm gingerly pulled out a dagger; he’d reuse the paper if he could, and looked at Hawk.

“You have no idea who this is from?”

“Probably someone who likes your chess newsletter thing. I hear that it gets good traction among the Drake cities. Didn’t you get a whole bunch of deliveries from the Runner’s Guild after some idiot spelled your name wrong or something?”

“Yeah, but no one’s sent a message by *Courier*—”

Olesm was fumbling with the plain wax seal. It wasn’t stamped, so whoever wanted to send this didn’t feel like broadcasting to the world who

they were. He was thinking about his chess newsletter. Yes, it was certainly possible, but what with all the dangers of the Goblin Lord and so forth, Olesm had completely missed sending his chess games and analysis for the last two weeks. And it wasn't like his chess newsletters had spread beyond the continent. So who—

His heart stopped as he pulled out the short message from the envelope. At the top of the creamy, soft paper flecked with bits of gold was an insignia he recognized. It was a wing, or rather, a stylized flowing wing comprised of three colors. Pink, yellow, and green, the same colors as the eyes of their leader. Olesm would have recognized the insignia anywhere as a [Tactician], and the inhaled breaths from Hawk and Pisces showed they both recognized it too.

The banner of the Forgotten Wing company stared up at Olesm. It was one of the Four Great Companies of Baleros. The Forgotten Wing Company. The Iron Vanguard. Maelstrom's Howling. And the Eyes of Baleros.

But of the four companies, this one mattered most. Because the greatest [Strategist] in the world led that company. And Olesm's eyes travelled slowly down the page, skipping the precise, neat handwriting and finding the signature at the bottom.

Niers Astoragon.

Olesm looked up. Hawk stared at the letter. Pisces' face was dead white. The [Mage] stared at the [Tactician]. The [Tactician] stared at the [Mage].

Hawk the Courier stared for a second longer and then whistled.

"Cool. That's great, Olesm. Glad I decided to deliver it. Hey, do you know anything about those Goblins in Erin's inn? I nearly kicked one when I came through the door. Hello? Guys?"

He peered at the two stunned chess lovers and shook his head.

“Never mind. I’ll go ask someone in a tavern. Let me know if you want to send a reply. It’s not listed on the contract, but I could ask. Later!”

He strode off. That broke the spell around Pisces and Olesm. They stared at each other, earlier arguments forgotten.

“Well? What does it say?”

Pisces was peering at the letter. Olesm hesitated, and then showed it to him. The two read it, and their faces turned paler. Olesm went line by line through the letter, muttering out loud in disbelief.

“To Olesm Swifttail...most impressed by your analysis...quality of the games represented...intriguing endeavor...attached puzzle I have compiled myself? *Looking forwards to future publications?* A SMALL TOKEN OF MY APPRECIATION!?”

He reached into the envelope and slowly lifted out a glinting brass ring. The insignia of an eye was set with a tiny diamond in the metal. Pisces stared at it. He stared at Olesm. Olesm threw up his hands. Pisces did likewise. The two screamed, and they began to dance wildly about, shouting in disbelief.

The people walking down the street halted and stared at the two as Olesm and Pisces danced about, shouting incoherently about chess and Niers and rings. They didn’t care, but it was the subject of much entertainment for everyone watching. Including the young woman and Drake standing down the street, munching on some toasted breadsticks dipped in cheese and watching everything.

“What are those two idiots doing?”

Selys and Erin paused as they watched Pisces and Olesm dancing about in the street. Erin shrugged.

“Dunno. They look happy, though. It’s weird seeing them together, isn’t it?”

Selys sniffed.

“Hatchlings are the same wherever you go. Anyways, forget them, Erin. You were telling me about the Goblins?”

“Oh, right!”

Erin began walking after Selys, leaving the dancing Pisces and Olesm behind. She sighed.

“It’s a problem. Not them, exactly, but pants.”

“Pants?”

“Yeah, we’re having a real pants crisis. They don’t like them. They want to wear their horrible old loincloths, but I made them get rid of them because they were nasty. Really nasty. But they’d rather walk around naked than with pants...”

“What, really? That’s disg—what do they look like?”

“*Selys!*”

“I’m just asking.”

“Mrsha lives in my inn!”

“Ooh. Okay, that’s a problem.”

“Yeah. She’s learned they’re a weak spot. And she *hates* the Goblins. So she keeps throwing things at them. She hit Badarrow right in the groin with

a pot the other day, and you know what happens when she doesn't like something. She *bites*. I want to avoid that. So if you know any good [Tailors]..."

"Let me introduce you to one right now. Don't you worry; Aunt Selys is on the job! That's Aunt Selys for Mrsha, obviously. Don't call me an Aunt, Erin. It'll make me feel old."

"Aw. Can I call you my cousin?"

"Maybe..."

They wandered off. Pisces and Olesm kept dancing, and eventually they stopped. Olesm handed the letter to Pisces, and with a trembling claw, put on the ring.

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“Argh! I’ve gone blind!”

Olesm’s first reaction upon putting on the ring was to roll about on the ground and scream. He felt like someone was stabbing his eyes out with toothpicks. Everything was spinning, confusing—blurring! He tried to focus his eyes on his claws, the sky, anything, but he didn’t see what he should have, just intense and very large blobs of color.

The agony persisted until someone grabbed Olesm roughly. He flailed at the person with his claws and felt someone grab one of his fingers. Olesm felt a hand twist the ring on his index claw and suddenly the world was back to normal. He blinked tears out of his eyes and saw Pisces standing over him.

“Wha—what happened?”

“The ring modifies your sight. Obviously.”

The [Necromancer] stepped back and Olesm sat up. A crowd of people had gathered around him. Olesm waved sheepishly at some people he knew. Pisces just sniffed. Olesm passed trembling claws in front of his face. Were they larger than they should be?

“Wow. A Ring of Sight? But when I put it on, everything was so—so—”

“The enchantment allows you to adjust the magnification effect by twisting the ring. It was not difficult to identify the nature of the spell. Which is clearly what you should have done before putting the ring on. Do you make a habit of using magical items without ascertaining their natures?”

Pisces stared pointedly at Olesm. The Drake felt the scales on his cheeks warm. He coughed and got up. Yes, the world *was* larger than it should be. He carefully twisted the ring on his fingers and felt everything slide back into normal focus.

“Um. Thank you, Pisces. Sorry, everyone. Just an unexpected incident with a magical artifact. Heh.”

The crowd dispersed, since that really *was* a usual occurrence and Olesm hadn’t done anything else interesting, like grow a second tail. Still very embarrassed, Olesm brushed at his clothes and looked at Pisces. He coughed, and the mage silently handed him the letter from Niers Astoragon.

“A Ring of Sight. An appropriate gift for a [Tactician] beginning his career. No doubt similar artifacts are used by most conventional strategists, hence the decision to gift one to you.”

“What? Right. Yeah, it’s good. I normally ask for magnification spells or—it’s good.”

Olesm peered at the letter again. The short missive still stunned him and he stared at the crest at the top of the letter. A letter from him. Niers Astoragon. If there was a hero among [Strategists], it was him. Everyone who respected planning, organization, smart strategy and—and anything having to do with that kind of thing respected Niers Astoragon.

He was famous for beating [Mages] and enemy [Generals] alike with his sophisticated mind games, and winning battles thought impossible with clever insight rather than brute force. Of course, he was a Fraerling; brute force wasn’t an option for him.

Olesm was a huge fan of his and clearly Pisces shared the same opinion. The [Necromancer] was inspecting the envelope carefully, even sniffing it. Olesm snatched it away from the mage and turned. His heart was racing. He had only one thought in his mind.

“I have to tell Erin about this!”

She would be so excited to hear what had happened. Or—did she know who Niers Astoragon was? She’d be excited when Olesm explained him to her. He began hurrying down the street. For some reason, Pisces followed him.

“It seems this chess newsletter has reaped quite a substantial reward. Especially for so little work.”

“What? Oh, yes. It has.”

Olesm frowned at Pisces. The [Necromancer]’s eyes were fixed on the letter in his claws, and the ring. Olesm had to prevent himself from fiddling with it; he’d have to find out exactly how far he could see with it. If the blinding images were anything to go by, it could probably magnify his sight many, many times over.

It wasn’t far to the gates and the streets were mostly empty. People still didn’t want to travel outside of the city for fear of Goblins—and because of the snow—and since Erin’s inn was now infested with said Goblins, no one really had business outside. Olesm waved at the Gnoll on duty as he hurried out. And Pisces was still following him.

“So you intend to tell Erin about your success.”

“Yeah, that’s the plan. Are you going to her inn as well?”

“I do reside there.”

Olesm frowned as he marched through wet snow, glad he’d put his boots on today. He didn’t exactly want Pisces to come to the inn. The [Necromancer] was staring at him with what felt like disapproval.

“Look, can I help you? Not to be rude, but I’ve just had a bit of great news and I’d like to share it with Erin. Alone.”

Pisces sniffed.

“Of course. And may I add that it is an entirely deserved reward for your hard effort?”

That was clearly sarcastic. Olesm slowed his frantic steps through the snow and glared at Pisces.

“Hey! What’s *that* supposed to mean?”

The [Mage] folded his arms.

“I would imagine my statements are self-explanatory.”

Olesm stared. Pisces rolled his eyes.

“Very well, if I must explain myself—I assume you are going to the inn to tell Erin exactly how wonderful the news of Niers Astoragon’s approval is. He has gifted you with his attention, a ring, and a chess puzzle for your, ah, publication.”

“That’s right. So what?”

Olesm glanced down at the letter in his claws. He couldn’t wait to try and solve the puzzle himself. He wondered if Erin could do it easily. It was a puzzle from the *Titan*! And Niers had also written that he’d love to know more about the game of Go that Olesm had mentioned in his last newsletter. If Erin could play a few games with him, maybe show Olesm a few tips—

Pisces’ voice broke through his rushing thoughts like a cold bar of iron.

“And you are sure you deserve such rewards? You, and no one else?”

The [Tactician] raised his head.

“What? Don’t be ridiculous! Of course I do! I wrote the newsletter! Are you jealous?”

That had to be it. Pisces was jealous of his good fortune and the ring. Olesm covered it with one claw. But Pisces' expression had now twisted into a sneer of contempt. He stomped through the snow and poked Olesm in the chest with one finger.

"It truly does amaze me. You have no concept of the irony of it, do you? You think Niers Astoragon cared for your newsletter? No. He cared for what you were a vehicle for—the games you so blatantly copied. He was impressed by *Erin Solstice*'s chess games, her expertise and abilities. Not yours. All your fleeting fame, your accolades, all stem from one person. Erin. Not you. If anyone deserves that ring and letter, it is she."

A hole opened up under Olesm's stomach. He felt it drop, and a terrible fear engulfed him. No. It couldn't be. He tried to protest.

"I—I did more than that! I added other games, my commentary. It wasn't all Erin. I just used her games—"

Her first games. Olesm's throat closed up as he remembered that he'd sent copies of her chess games with every letter. Pisces sneered.

"Ah yes, your commentary. Was it all lauding her brilliant moves, or did you copy her remarks as well? Certainly you deserve praise—for your abilities as a [Scribe]. Not as a [Tactician]. Least of all as someone with any original thought worthy of merit."

With each sentence, Pisces poked Olesm again. The words cut deeply at Olesm, but the shame and pain twisted in his gut and turned into anger. The Drake knocked the accusing hand away and lashed his tail in the snow.

"Shut up! I had the idea at first! Yes, I copied down Erin's games, but she gave me permission, and who else had this idea? Shouldn't I get credit for that?"

“Didn’t Miss Solstice herself suggest to you to expand your newsletter? I heard she was familiar with the exact same concept you thought was so original.”

Pisces crossed his arms and Olesm bit his tongue guiltily. That was right. Erin said it *was* like something she’d seen. Magazines, she’d called them. Monthly newsletters about chess. But he hadn’t known that!

But now Pisces was pressing the attack. The Human glared at Olesm in the snow just outside of Liscor, his eyes filled with scorn.

“You are nothing more than a copycat. If Niers Astoragon knew that the sum of all your accomplishments was nothing more than an opportunistic thief stealing from someone else’s talent, he would never have sent a letter, much less a ring—”

“*Shut up!*”

Olesm couldn’t bear it any longer. He bent down, gathered a handful of wet snow, and hurled it at Pisces. The mage tried to dodge, but the snow smacked him across the face and shoulder. He brushed it away, looking outraged. Olesm glared at him.

“I don’t have to hear that from you. Yes, I took Erin’s games and showed them to people. Yes, she’s one of the reasons why people are so impressed. But *I* still did all this. Me! And no matter what you say, the fact is that you’re just jealous that Niers Astoragon knows my name. Whereas you’re a mage everyone hates, just a step above a graverobber!”

He bent and scooped up more snow and hurled it at Pisces. The mage stepped away, face crimson with anger, but Olesm was too incensed to care.

“I bet you wish you’d done what I did. Well, you *didn’t*. And now that someone famous knows me, *me*, you’d better believe I’ll use that and start making more newsletters as fast as I can! That’s what I’ve done! What have

you accomplished? You—you spineless [Necromancer]! What have you done, other than steal from people and cause trouble? Ceria and the Horns of Hammerad are the best thing that ever happened to you! What have you got besides them?”

Olesm realized he was shouting. He didn’t know where that last bit had come from, only that it stemmed from the frustration in his chest. He threw a third wet snowball at Pisces. This time he missed completely.

The [Mage] stood in the snow, watching Olesm. The Drake was panting. Pisces’ face was white with anger. The truce that had been caused by Niers’ letter had been broken, and now their previous conversation rose into the air, making it hot and uncomfortable.

Pisces glanced over Olesm’s shoulder. He narrowed his eyes at the Drake and adjusted something on his belt. A bag of holding? Olesm glanced at it and a small bell began ringing in his mind. His [Dangersense]. But then Pisces began to speak.

“What have *I* accomplished? Turn and see.”

There was a rustling. A sound. Olesm whirled and *something* burst out of the snow behind him. He yelped and fell backwards, scrabbling for his sword, as a pale yellow and white creature exploded upwards in a shower of snow. It was tall, thin, ivory bones swinging into place, a burning eye of green flame staring down at Olesm—

A scythe of bone swung down in front of the Drake’s face. Olesm froze. His eyes slowly travelled upwards. Yes, it was a scythe of bone, a curved claw sharpened to a cutting edge. But it was not a weapon. Rather, the scythe *was* the creature’s arm. And the long, whip-like assembly of bone led upwards to a strange, narrow body without a head. Olesm’s breath came in short, sharp bursts.

What was he staring at? A monster. No, an abomination made of bone. The creature that stood in the snow had a thin torso and a long, spider-like lower half. Four legs reminiscent of a spider's held the thing up, but an odd, cylindrical waist connected the upper half to the lower. It had no head, but rather, a single central socket and 'eye' of flaming light set in the center of the torso, which was shaped like an inverted teardrop.

The two arms with scythes on each end were long enough to trail on the ground, and while the 'hands' were the sickles of cutting bone, the creature had wicked barbs of bone sticking out along the edges of its arms. Olesm gulped as the scythe-hand near his face slowly retracted. He watched in horror and fascination as the thing backed up a few steps, and then collapsed into a pile of bones.

"Wha—what was—"

"My worth."

Pisces was smiling as Olesm staggered around. The Drake felt he needed to sit, so he did. Straight into the snow. Pisces smirked at that, then his head turned to the walls of Liscor. He searched the battlements, but if the [Guardsmen] on sentry duty had seen the bone thing, no one had raised the alarm.

So they hadn't seen it. Because Olesm felt sure that anyone who'd seen Pisces' creation would raise every alarm in existence, if they didn't just run away screaming first. He looked at Pisces. The [Necromancer] turned back to him. Only now did Olesm recover his voice.

"What was *that*? What in the name of scales—"

"As I said. My worth. That is my latest creation. A Bone Horror."

"A *Bone*—"

Olesm's mouth gaped open. He'd heard of such things, of course. Skeletons were only one kind of undead that could emerge in mass graves or places of death. Fortunately, such occurrences were rare and the remains were usually disposed of quickly, but given enough time, fractured pieces of bone, half-destroyed corpses, and so on could form horrible amalgamation undead, like Crypt Lords and Bone Horrors.

But Olesm was sure, *sure* that such undead were far beyond the abilities of most low-level necromancers to create. Wasn't the general rule of thumb that a [Necromancer] could only animate an undead equivalent to half of his levels? Or was it two thirds? Was it higher if he had a specific Skill? Olesm's internal mind told him he would be reading every book on necromancy that night, but his conscious brain told him only one thing. Pisces had created a Bone Horror. It was his.

He'd made it. And for some reason, now Olesm saw Pisces as the other people in Liscor surely had. Zombies, skeletons like Toren, even Ghouls were one thing. But that? No creature on earth looked like that. Or if they did, they were as twisted as Crelers. No, Pisces had created that himself. It was a manifestation of his ideas. He'd brought that horror into existence.

"Why would you make something like that?"

Pisces was walking through the snow. He passed by Olesm, and the bones floated upwards. The Drake flinched, but they were floating into the bag of holding that Pisces carried at his side. The [Necromancer] turned his head, speaking casually.

"For combat. Why else? Naturally I cannot animate such a being for extended durations; indeed, I have not shared its existence with my teammates yet, since their reactions would probably mirror yours. However, given proper time to prepare—say, before challenging a particularly dangerous monster—this Bone Horror will doubtless prove useful. What you saw was a prototype, of course."

“A prototype.”

“Indeed. You noted the long arms? For mobile attacks. When used in conjunction with the four legs, this variant—what I term the Scythe Crawler—is very quick and able to attack its opponents from many angles a conventional creature would not. It is able to rotate freely about the waist, allowing strikes from improbable angles.”

“Improbable angles.”

“Indeed. However, this is only one variant I have come up with. Given the bones I have collected thus far—and I would like to expand that collection if I can purchase a superior bag of holding—I have ideas for a more powerful version. This one is regrettably weak against armored foes. But one with enhanced limbs and perhaps a ranged attack—”

“Ranged attack?”

“Yes, firing bones. It is possible to turn parts of the skeletal structure into a catapult, although, obviously, ammunition would be limited. But if combined with a recall spell, it could be useful. I haven’t worked out the exact specifications yet, but I am pleased with the results so far—”

Pisces finished bagging the last of the bones and turned. He’d been chattering excitedly, but now he stopped when he saw Olesm’s face. The slight smile that he’d been wearing vanished and was replaced by his customary look of disdain in an instant.

“Ah. Forgive me. I believe we were discussing achievements? Well, you may not acknowledge mine, but I consider it equivalent to any such letters. It is another step in my career. You may scorn it as you wish.”

Olesm felt like throwing up. Pisces turned away. The Drake stared at his back. He realized the look on his face was probably what Pisces saw all the time in the city. And yet, he couldn’t suppress the disturbed feeling in his

chest. He didn't know if he should. So instead he asked the only question he could think of.

"Is that why Selys was angry with you? Because you wanted to bring *that* into the city?"

"Do you take me for a fool? Of course not!"

Pisces snapped at Olesm. He looked like he regretted scaring Olesm with his creation. His eyes flicked towards the walls again. He shook his head.

"I—was talking to her about a similar but unrelated matter. A trifle. I simply offered her to resolve the issue of giant rats within Liscor's sewers."

"What? Oh. We have a bounty on them, but no one wants to take it."

"Quite. It is a disgusting job with risk of infection, not to mention disease. The rats live in the drainage pipes, growing overly large due to magical waste improperly disposed of...hunting down their nests would require crawling through pipes, a task few adventurers are willing to contemplate, however low-level they might be."

"But you were willing to do it?"

Olesm stared at Pisces. The [Mage] looked affronted.

"I would rather die. But I offered to send one of my constructs into the sewers. A creation similar to the Bone Horror, whose task would be solely to destroy any rats below. It would be mobile, created for tight engagements, and naturally advantageous given a rat's limited physical weapons against bone. But Miss Shivertail denied my proposal without deigning to relay it to her Guildmistress, citing city laws—"

"Oh. Right. That makes sense. We don't let undead into the city for any reason."

“So she was telling the truth.”

Pisces’ face grew pinched. He gritted his teeth together, speaking sharply through them.

“Nevertheless, she could have *asked*. But apparently her grandmother—a fine case of nepotism in practice—distrusts necromancy. So rational thought is once again done away with, and my suggestion is deemed meritless before any actual consideration. Due to prejudice.”

He glanced at Olesm and shook his head.

“Pah. I suppose it should not surprise me. Those who would decry an entire school of magic for one or two bad examples are clearly not worthy of coherent thought. Or my time.”

He turned away. Olesm sat up in the snow. He blinked at Pisces’ back. Olesm raised his voice as Pisces began to stomp back towards Liscor.

“I think it’s a good idea.”

“What?”

Pisces turned. He blinked at Olesm. Olesm wiped some snow off of his shoulder absently.

“I said I think it’s a good idea. Your sewer plan, that is.”

“You—you do?”

“Yeah. We haven’t been able to work out a good plan for clearing them for years now. We’ve tried spells—the rats just eat them or expend all the charges too fast. We try poison and they adapt. Plus, the sewers are pretty much poison as they are already, so...we try adventurers and they never get enough. We waste money on the issue and every now and then the rats swarm out of the sewers, which is a disaster.”

Olesm shuddered at the memories. He looked at Pisces.

“You have a good idea. I get why Selys turned down your proposal, though. Her grandmother would kick you tail-over-head out of the door in an instant. But I could authorize your idea myself.”

“What?”

“I *am* the city’s lone [Tactician]. I might not be exactly as important as Watch Captain Zevara, but I can do a lot on my own authority. Striking a deal and writing out a permit for a single undead under your supervision is within my jurisdiction.”

As he spoke, Olesm’s tail lifted towards his mouth. He gnawed on the tip for a second before realizing what he was doing and spitting it out. He coughed, feeling like a hatchling again.

“How does ten gold pieces sound to begin with? We could put a bounty of...I don’t know, one copper piece per ten rats killed? If your undead works with your mana it could kill thousands over the course of weeks. That’s hundreds of gold pieces for you.”

Pisces’ jaw dropped. He stared at the Drake [Tactician] and looked around as if he suspected a prank. He pointed at Olesm.

“But you—I could have sworn you thought—what of my latest creation?”

“That? That was disgusting.”

Olesm shuddered. Pisces’ eyes were fixed on him. The mage raised his hands angrily.

“And?”

“And what?”

His bottom was wet. Olesm returned Pisces' gaze, breathing a bit hard.

“Not liking undead is one thing, but I'm not an idiot, Pisces. Look, that Bone Horror was—horrible. I think it's disgusting. If you summon—animate, whatever, bring it to life again, I will throw up, hit you with my sword, and run away. Maybe not in that order. I hate undead, and that probably won't change. But that doesn't mean I think your ideas aren't good. Can't thinking, rational adults like us respect each other's boundaries and still work together?”

For a solid minute, the Drake and Human just stared at each other in silence. Pisces was blinking, caught off-guard. Olesm was wet. He shifted and hoped that Niers' letter hadn't gotten soggy. But his legs didn't want to stand just yet, so he stayed put. Pisces stared at Olesm and seemed to notice Olesm's state at last.

“Ah. You are sitting in the snow. You appear to be quite wet.”

Olesm looked around. His tail was very cold and sitting in a rather deep and melting drift. He nodded slowly.

“So I am.”

Pisces stared. Then, slowly, he bent and offered Olesm a hand up. And, after a second, Olesm took it.

“I do apologize for my earlier comments. They were deliberately inflammatory and designed to offend. I believe the merit of your work is self-evident and did not deserve my scorn in the slightest.”

“No, no, I have to admit that you had a good point. And I haven't been nearly as gracious as I should be. True, I don't like undead, but I can admire

your, uh, Bone Horror from a design perspective. And it's true that your ideas really are just what the city needs. I should apologize as well."

"Perish the thought. I would prefer to let bygones be bygones. It is rather agreeable to meet someone else with a rational mindset, not to mention a similar perspective, after toiling for so long alone."

"Indeed it is."

A Drake and a Human walked through the snow around Liscor, talking animatedly. They were not headed in the direction of the Wandering Inn or back to Liscor. Instead, they were just...chatting.

Olesm kicked through the snow as Pisces' robe left a trail of its own. Neither Human nor Drake noticed; they were too caught up in their conversation. After the ice had metaphorically and literally melted between them, the two had realized that they were different, but alike in many agreeable ways.

They were both young, both considered themselves thoughtful as opposed to impulsive—a choice reflected in their respective classes, and both shared a love for strategy, planning, and so on. Olesm was stunned to realize that, in many respects, Pisces was like him.

For one thing, Pisces had probably the most complete understanding of Drake politics that Olesm had ever met outside of another Drake. He was up to date on the latest world events and could discuss issues like the Germina-Reim incident and subsequent Hellios conflict without having to be reminded of the details. He had read widely about Niers Astoragon's historical campaigns, knew several facts about Baleros that Olesm did not, and was an expert on Terandrian culture and politics.

He was incredible. And it was clear that Pisces considered Olesm a fellow peer, which was a compliment in itself from Pisces. But what the

two really bonded over was their situations as young individuals trying to make their mark on the world.

“It’s all politics, Pisces. Everyone wagging their tails for one side or another, and no real focus on *merit*. I got my job in the city because I was the highest-leveled, yes, but my family had to kiss a lot of claws to get me where I was. But even though I am the city’s [Tactician], everyone in the council meetings ignores me when they feel like it because I’m young. As if seniority matters that much! I’m higher-level than at least two of the council members!”

Olesm shook his head, lashing the snow behind him angrily. Pisces nodded, lips pursing.

“It is ever the same across nations, I’m afraid. In Terandria, the issue of personal power is compounded by bloodlines. Seeking friendship with the nobility is practically a requirement. As for wealth—”

“If you’re not rich, you won’t move a single tail your way. Yeah, I know. But it feels like to *have* wealth you need wealth, you know? I get paid a little bit from my salary, but if I wanted to command any respect I’d have to invest heavily into some profitable venture, or uncover a boatload of treasure—”

“You need not explain yourself to me, Olesm. Adventuring, like magic, is similarly gated. In Wistram, the older mages controlled the access to spellbooks with an iron grip. But if they had simply shared their largely redundant collections, everyone might profit! Instead, here we are, forced to scrabble along until we are as aged and decrepit as the fools who kept us down to begin with...”

Pisces sighed. Olesm patted him on the shoulder with a sympathetic claw. They walked onwards.

“You really did have a good thing with that Bone Horror. I mean, it’s disgusting for me, true, but I’d love to see it tearing up a Creler rather than anyone risk their lives.”

“Precisely the use undead were intended for! Please say that to Springwalker or Miss Byres. And you were impressed by the arms, were you not?”

“Oh, yeah! Whip-like attacks, all those barbs—it makes sense, doesn’t it? I imagine it’s a lot stronger than those bears you rode in on the other week.”

The mage smiled slyly.

“Actually, those *were* the bears.”

“Get out.”

Olesm stared at him. Pisces waved a hand.

“No, no. It was just a matter of carving some of the bones, rearranging others—you see the Bone Horror is a product of my increased mastery of bones in general. In fact, the ability to create such a being directly correlates to my current level. I, ah, reached Level 30 just the other day.”

“No way! You? But why didn’t you tell anyone?”

Pisces smiled proudly.

“I wished to keep it a secret. Let us just say that I experienced several revelations...and for my Level 30 Skill, I obtained a greater mastery of bone shaping. However, I might add that the ability to create Draugr would have been another common Skill at that level.”

“Draugr? That would be impressive. Those are like super-undead, right? I remember hearing about how a hundred of those could smash through most formations—”

“True. But I consider Bone Horrors superior.”

“What? No. Why? A Draugr—”

“Think about it, Olesm. True, a Draugr is impressive, but it requires a body, nay, relies on the strength of the deceased for full potency. In addition, it is harder to store such corpses, whereas a Bone Horror...”

“...Can be reanimated at will! And kept in a bag of holding! Of course!”

Olesm snapped at his forehead. Pisces nodded, smiling happily.

“In addition, I believe I can make such creations far stronger than typical examples. Consider my variant—it is far better structured than the default amalgamation the spell produces. Indeed, my ability to specialize such undead will allow infinite forms for any contingency. Plus, if I create a few custom undead rather than mass-animate them, they will be far superior. That is my belief.”

“Really? You hear about [Necromancers] raising undead in big armies all the time. Isn’t that more mana-efficient?”

“It is. But that is hardly conducive to secrecy or positive relations with other groups, is it? Moreover, the inefficiency of mass-produced undead...”

Pisces shook his head, looking troubled. He grumbled to himself under his breath.

“It is strange that legends fail to see why vast armies of largely similar creations are flawed. Whereas if the designs for undead were altered en masse and used as the template for future spells, the potential of a zombie or skeleton would be far *greater*. How can someone not see that? Experimentation is the key to growth, not—”

He broke off and eyed Olesm for a moment before laughing lightly and shaking his head.

“Forgive me. It seems I am the only [Necromancer] who believes in the total assurance of quality over quantity.”

“That’s too bad. Or rather, good, I guess. If other [Necromancers] were like you, we’d be in a lot more trouble when they appear.”

Olesm grinned at Pisces. The [Mage] looked surprised, as he always did when Olesm paid him a compliment, and then laughed.

“True.”

They walked a bit more through the snow when Olesm cleared his throat. He’d had a thought while walking with Pisces. Their conversation was excellent, of course, but it occurred to him that the [Mage] could allow him to check up on his theory at the same time.

“Do you mind if we head this way while we walk?”

Pisces glanced in the indicated direction, away from Liscor and up a snowy hill. His eyes flicked to Olesm’s face for a moment, but he only nodded.

“Not at all.”

He’d already figured out where they were going based on direction alone. True, it was an easy conclusion if you thought about it, but Olesm still admired the way Pisces had come to it so flawlessly. He coughed, and brought up another subject on his mind.

“Er, Pisces. I know you and the Horns of Hammerad have been doing a lot of missions together.”

“We have enjoyed some success, yes. Although right now we are simply keeping busy rather than aiming at one goal. Our tasks are by and large simplistic.”

Pisces waved a hand. Olesm nodded. He cleared his throat again, feeling extremely embarrassed.

“Right. So you spend a lot of time with Ceria. And you’re old friends from Wistram.”

“Old friends. I suppose you could say that, yes.”

“Uh huh. So she talks to you I bet. Does she...does she ever mention me at all?”

The Drake halted in the snow. Pisces turned his head, looking amused and trying to cover that amusement at the same time.

“You wonder if Ceria harbors feelings for you still?”

“No, no, I was just curious if she felt—yes.”

Olesm hung his head, tail drooping. The sympathetic look in Pisces’ eye told him all he needed to know. Pisces hesitated before cautiously patting Olesm on the back with one tentative hand.

“I regret to say she does not mention her feelings to me in that regard. In other regards, yes. But in this...she may still be receptive.”

“No. No. I just wondered if—I mean, we weren’t a couple long. We didn’t actually do many couple-like things, actually. We just uh—but I thought—”

Olesm’s cheeks were flushing. He blinked at suddenly painful eyes. Pisces averted his gaze and cleared his throat tactfully. After a long pause, he spoke.

“I do not believe the fault was yours, if there was any fault to assign for the demise of any, ah, relationship between you two, Olesm. Springwalker—I mean Ceria, is a half-Elf. They do not value long-term relationships with other species, by and large.”

“I know that. But I thought she and I had something.”

“Perhaps you did.”

There was a sympathetic look in Pisces’ eyes as he shook his head.

“Ceria is used to mobility, travel. She is an adventurer *and* a half-Elf. She is used to persecution for simply existing in Terandria, and I do not believe she is looking for a long-term partner. Speaking as one who has also had a relationship with Ceria, I think she seeks temporary solace, not love.”

“Someone who—*what*? You and Ceria were—you two?”

Olesm’s head snapped up. Pisces blinked, and then he looked the other way.

“I, ah, misspoke. We were only together for—”

“You two used to be together? When? In Wistram? Wait, is that why she hates you now?”

“Ahem. It is long past, and it would be inaccurate to call our connection anything more than a brief passing of ships.”

Pisces shook his head, but Olesm refused to let it go. The Drake walked in front of Pisces.

“Come on. Tell me. How close were you two? Why’d you break up?”

The [Necromancer] halted in his tracks and looked away. He bit his lip, and then replied.

“I don’t believe we were ever together, Olesm. Not truly. There was a time, once—but it never came to be. I misspoke earlier. Please do not repeat that to Ceria. I think she would take it amiss if she learned what I said.”

Olesm hesitated. He knew he should drop it, but he couldn’t.

“Why’d it never come to be, though?”

Again, the Human hesitated. When he looked back, it was with badly-concealed pain in his eyes. He really wasn’t that good a liar if you looked past the sneer he was always wearing like a mask.

“She learned the truth. Who I am. Before I could explain. That was all.”

The memory of the Bone Horror resurfaced in Olesm’s mind. He stopped, and his tail drooped.

“Sorry. I’m uh, sorry. I shouldn’t have asked.”

Pisces shrugged, covering up his emotions with indifference. He glanced past Olesm.

“It is no matter. The memory only troubles me at times. And it appears we have appeared at another memory. Tell me, why are we here?”

Olesm turned. He hadn’t noticed it, but they had come up on a large, excavated hillside. He cautiously ascended a few more steps and found himself staring into a dark, stone doorway looming amid the half-excavated stonework. This was not the dungeon’s entrance. No. This was the crypt.

They had thought it was the dungeon at first. Olesm remembered Klbkch delivering the report to Zevara and all the speculation it had caused. He remembered the expeditions of adventurers going in, and then the fated one that had included the Horns of Hammerad. And then the night when Skinner had overrun the gates with an army of undead—

The night he had been down there. In the darkness, fighting for his life, hiding from the undead with Ceria in the coffins. Olesm shuddered. He felt terribly afraid of the crypt. Pisces stared at the dark opening, and then at the Drake.

“It was clear you intended to come here. The reason is what I cannot fathom.”

“It’s a...hunch. Look, I’m realizing this might be a bad idea more and more, but you’re a powerful [Necromancer]; I feel like I’d be safe with you if we went inside, right?”

“To do what, exactly?”

Olesm patted at his pockets.

“Follow up on that hunch. Remember the report I asked for at the Adventurer’s Guild?”

“Yes.”

“Well, I noticed some discrepancies in another file a while back. I never had time to check it out—and I wasn’t confident enough to ask Zevara for an escort before now. Let’s go inside and I’ll tell you about it. Unless you think it might be dangerous?”

Pisces eyed the dark opening, and then shrugged. He reached for his bag of holding and poured the bones onto the ground. Olesm shuddered as the Bone Horror rose upwards. It scuttled into the large opening and Pisces motioned towards it.

“My creation should attract any monsters inside, and we will be forewarned in case of most threats. Moreover, I believe the crypts were cleared recently, so I don’t anticipate any true danger. Unless you do?”

“Not danger.”

“Then let us enter.”

Slowly, the two walked into the darkness. Pisces conjured a ball of light and Olesm shuddered as he looked around the crypts. Yes, it was just like

he remembered. The excavated rooms, still full of dirt and tracks, the haunting echoes, the temple decorations...

Pisces walked next to Olesm, looking around, frowning ahead, monitoring his creation's progress probably. Olesm remembered that Pisces had also come here, to rescue Ceria and Olesm both a lifetime ago. He closed his eyes on the thought and nearly tripped.

"Careful."

The Human caught him. Olesm shook his head.

"Sorry. I'm just—memories, you know?"

"Yes."

Pisces' eyes were sympathetic. He looked around.

"Now would you enlighten me?"

"Yeah. Let me just collect my thoughts for a moment."

The two walked onwards, through narrow corridors, towards the tunnel sloping downwards to the second level. Olesm felt his scales tingling, but told himself there was no danger. If there were undead, Pisces would have sensed them. This place was nothing more than a grave now. It had always been a grave, but now the occupants were silent.

"So like I said, I noticed something when looking through one of the old reports. It's my job to file a lot of paperwork and I remembered this one. So I was looking...you know that all of the adventurers' possessions were confiscated by the city afterwards, right?"

"Yes. I do recall. Everything but what Ceria, Yvlon, and the few survivors carried was taken. A group of guardsmen cleared this place of the last of the undead. What of it?"

“Well, we did an inventory. Naturally. Weapons we didn’t need were sold and we repurposed the magical artifacts, potions, and so on. We also did a tally of the dead. A...rough count since so many were—were attacked by Skinner. Identification was impossible, but we knew they were Drakes, Gnolls, Humans, and so on from the bones, right?”

“Yes. Was there something wrong with your count?”

“Just one.”

Olesm’s breath came in short, sharp bursts as they descended the ramp leading downwards. He remembered. A group of running zombies had come up the corridor. And beyond that, the ambush—Pisces gripped his arm and Olesm caught himself.

“What was I...? Yeah, I found one discrepancy, but I had to make sure. This report is from the Adventurer’s Guild. I didn’t really need it; I already had the one the Watch filed. But I had to make sure both were the same. And they were.”

“And who was missing?”

Pisces’ gaze turned to Olesm’s. The [Necromancer] walked through the darkness, his face illuminated by the soft yellow light of his spell, calm, waiting. Olesm looked at him.

“You already know.”

After a second, the mage nodded.

“There is only one individual whose remains would stand out enough to warrant positive identification, regardless of loss of skin.”

The two came to the intersection. Olesm felt his heart pounding in his chest. Pisces looked left and right. He spoke one word.

“Calruz.”

“Yes. The guardsmen never found his remains. Not his bones, nor his axe. And they should have found something, even if he was torn apart. His body wasn’t listed among the undead that attacked Liscor—not that he could have been reanimated that fast. And there’s no way he would have escaped and not gone to Liscor, so I thought—”

Olesm trailed off. It was stupid, now he said it out loud. He looked down the corridors. He remembered hearing the screaming in the distance, hearing the others wonder aloud where the other Silver-rank teams were. The sound of something dragging itself closer.

But there was nothing here now. He tried to reassure himself. Pisces stared around.

“You think he’s still down here. But it has been months. He would not have survived.”

“Right. Obviously.”

Olesm bit his lip. Pisces glanced at him.

“So you want to find his remains? You believe his corpse was overlooked?”

“Yeah. Maybe in a crevice or some secret door. It’s—look, I know it’s silly, but he fought with us, with me. I might be dead if he hadn’t charged Skinner. If I can find his body—”

“I understand. But it is a vast space. Do you really think we can find where he fell?”

The Drake hesitated.

“We can try.”

It was dark. The light of Pisces' magic was the only source of illumination in the darkness, casting long shadows and making everything seem just as frightening as it was. Olesm was glad for the light, though. Without it he might have panicked. The memories here were too strong.

At least he could see well. Maybe it was his ring, but the corridors seemed as bright as day. Pisces and Olesm walked down hallways, peering into rooms and trying to comb the place systematically. They were watchful for undead, of course, although Pisces insisted he didn't sense anything. His Bone Horror kept prowling down corridors around them; it had scared the life out of Olesm twice now.

"I think we're nearly done with this area. There's only the treasure room where Skinner emerged from, and it was looted by something."

"Indeed. Shall we pass through it just to be certain?"

"Yeah."

The huge stone doors still stood wide open. Olesm breathed in at the sight; he could recall the two Silver-rank teams agreeing to stand watch while the Horns of Hammerad searched the rest of the crypt. They'd *known* something might be lurking behind the door. They just didn't know that Skinner could open the door himself.

The room was emptied of all goods just like before. Olesm frowned around at it; Pisces picked up a stone amulet and tossed it down in disgust.

"I take it the city still does not know who made off with the treasures inside?"

"No. And I'm not sure if there were any."

“Come now. The guardian of the crypts must have guarded something of worth.”

“Yeah. But in that case, where is it?”

Pisces could only shrug. Olesm looked around helplessly and frowned.

“Nothing. Let’s go. We only have to check out that last room and we’re done.”

“What room?”

“That one, of course. You walked right past it.”

The Drake walked back out of the treasure room. Pisces followed, frowning. Olesm pointed to the doorway ahead of him, just opposite the double doors. Pisces stared at the doorway, and then at Olesm.

“I don’t see anything.”

“What? Don’t yank my tail. It’s right h—”

Olesm stepped forwards towards the doorway. Someone yanked him back. He stumbled and turned to Pisces angrily.

“Hey! What’s the big id—”

“Illusion.”

The [Mage]’s face was suddenly concentrated. He nodded at Olesm’s ring as one hand fell back to the rapier at his side. Olesm froze, and then realized what he meant.

“You think the Ring of Sight that Niers Astoragon gave me—?”

“What better gift for a [Tactician] than a true view of the battlefield? I see only a wall. And I cannot detect any illusion here. Not that I am gifted in such things, you understand, but it means this illusion is a good one.”

“It just looks like an open doorway to me.”

“Hm.”

Carefully, Pisces approached the open doorway, and slid his hand across what looked like empty air to Olesm. The Drake held his breath.

“It’s solid? I mean, it feels solid even when you push?”

“Yes. A powerful illusion. Here, grab my hand.”

Pisces reached out and Olesm gingerly took his hand. The Drake walked forwards and Pisces walked behind him through the doorway. Pisces shuddered as he passed through the stone opening.

“You okay?”

“I felt as though I was walking through stone. No, I am not. But the sensation is done with. Now, what do we have here?”

The stone doorway led a few feet ahead, into a small, circular room with a strange, hexagonal symbol drawn onto the floor. It was a small room; large enough to fit a few people inside perhaps. Olesm stepped forwards curiously and Pisces grabbed him again.

“*Gah!* Stop *doing* that!”

“Stop stepping into uncertain situations, then. You don’t know what that pattern on the floor does.”

“Neither do you.”

“True, but I do not intend to touch it myself. Observe. This is appropriate caution.”

Pisces reached for his belt and fumbled with a pouch. Olesm nearly jumped out his scales as the mage lifted out a tiny Shield Spider. The

[Necromancer] casually flicked it towards the opening and the spider began crawling into the alcove.

“What the—do you just carry Shield Spiders around?”

“It’s undead. Obviously.”

The [Necromancer] flicked his fingers and the spider scurried towards the hexagonal space on the floor. Olesm was about to point out that carrying around undead Shield Spiders didn’t make any more sense than living ones when the spider crossed onto the hexagonal floor and the ground vanished.

“Whoa!”

Olesm recoiled as the Shield Spider dropped out of view. Pisces held up a hand and Olesm heard the faintest of sounds from the opening.

“It seems there is a rather long drop below. Fortunately, my Shield Spider was not harmed by the fall. It appears to have dropped into a large room. Full of bones.”

“Really? What else is down there?”

“Give me a second. I will look through the eyes of my creation.”

Pisces broke off and Olesm shifted from foot to foot as he eyed the opening. He was just opening his mouth when the hexagonal hole suddenly filled again, and the floor was stone once more. Pisces smirked and gestured to the floor with one hand.

“See there? If we were incautious adventurers foolish enough to explore the opening, we would have fallen into the trap and been caught down there ourselves. What a simplistic trick.”

“Right. That would have been really stupid.”

Pisces chuckled and Olesm laughed along weakly. He'd been about to suggest they investigate the opening in person. Pisces tapped at his lips as he studied the room below through his undead construct's eyes.

“Yes, there are many bones around me, Olesm. Many, many bones. However, you may be interested to know that all of these bones are, apparently, organized and have been so for a long time.”

“Meaning?”

“Meaning that the owners of said remains died years, possibly centuries, before any adventurers came here.”

Olesm's breath caught in his chest. He had a thought.

“And there are no Minotaur skulls in the room?”

“None.”

“You're sure? How big is the room? I mean—”

Pisces turned a reproving eye towards Olesm.

“I know what Minotaur bones look like. There are none similar to it, although there are quite a number of unusual bones. Very odd. They appear similar to a Gnoll's in structure, but thicker. The skulls have a smaller cranial capacity and the jaws are enlarged...”

“Raskghar. They have to be.”

“What?”

Olesm quickly explained about the Gnoll's primitive subterranean cousins. Pisces nodded.

“Ah. That would explain much. Yes, the majority of the bones in the room do appear to be these...Raskghar. One moment. I am coming to a conclusion.”

“Are you? I’ve got one too.”

“Hm. Enlighten me, then.”

“This was probably meant to be a disposal place of some kind. I doubt it was meant as transportation; otherwise there would be a way back up. And why would it be hidden? I bet the undead were supposed to dump their victims down there.”

“I concur. And?”

“...That’s all I’ve got. You’re the one who can see down there.”

“True. Ah, I suppose it is time for my analysis.”

Pisces cleared his throat and stood straighter, adopting a lecturing tone that still irked Olesm a bit. But the Drake listened, mainly because he didn’t have any other choice.

“It looks like this was indeed meant to be used as a disposal chute—perhaps for invaders or the, ah, remains after Skinner had disposed of his foes. Yes, it would be an ideal spot for such parts to reanimate. However, this room has been repurposed. It appears to be a burial chamber now.”

“How do you—”

Pisces raised three fingers as he spoke, frowning at Olesm as he spoke over the Drake.

“I base my conclusions on three pieces of evidence. First, the bones within are systematically piled up, with the skull at the apex of each pile, clearly denoting some sort of ritualistic and continual disposal process. Second, the bones have been separated from the body and I can spot evidence that some tool was used to scrape the bones clean of flesh. Third, none of the skeletons have been damaged by scavengers, which implies the room is regularly swept and maintained. Except in a few notable cases...”

He paused for a second and coughed. Olesm silently offered him a water flask and Pisces took a drink before continuing.

“There is a disturbance where my Shield Spider landed, which threw me off at first. However, it appears that this was an anomaly. The nearest pile to the opening has been knocked into pieces. The bones are scattered, as if from a large impact overhead. They have disturbed a few other piles, but there are several overturned piles, as if something large ran into them. The path leads straight to the sole exit in the room. Your thoughts?”

Olesm’s mind raced. He spoke slowly.

“It seems obvious. Something—or rather, someone found this opening and walked into the trap. They landed on the pile and ran towards the door.”

Pisces nodded approvingly. His gaze unfocused again.

“And here, at the door—”

He drew in his breath sharply. Olesm stared at him.

“What?”

“A skeleton. Another Raskghar. However, this one was not ritually buried. The corpse is mostly decomposed and in one piece. And there is a weapon buried in its chest. A battleaxe. The haft is broken off.”

A battleaxe. Olesm’s tail lashed the ground. He started for the hole and Pisces grabbed him.

“Don’t be a fool! If you go down there we might not be able to return!”

“But a battleaxe—”

“I know. But allow my spider to proceed. There is but one exit. Next is a long corridor. There are several uneven tiles and—”

Pisces broke off with a cry. He winced as Olesm stared at him and shook his head.

“A trap. I could not identify it through the spider’s eyes. Whatever it was destroyed my creation. Thoroughly.”

“Do you have another spider? Or can you send something else? Can you animate the bones below?”

“I do not carry multiple spiders around as a rule. And the stone is preventing me from reaching the bones below. I do not sense them with my magic. Clearly we are not meant to know this passage exists.”

“But someone found it. Someone found it and fell. And they fought a Raskghar, killed it, but lost their battleaxe. And only one adventurer in our group carried one...”

Olesm stared at the hole. He turned to Pisces.

“Do you think it’s possible?”

The [Necromancer] shrugged. He was looking around warily, Olesm noticed, and as the Drake turned, he saw the Bone Horror had returned.

“It is possible. More than likely, perhaps. What of it? The Minotaur might have survived all of this, but he was wounded as he fled, was he not?”

“He lost his arm. The undead swarmed him. But—”

“Do you think he could have survived the rest of the dungeon in his condition?”

“I don’t know, but if he’s alive, we have to search for him!”

Olesm flared up. Pisces grabbed Olesm and slapped him across the face. The Drake gaped at him. Pisces was breathing fast.

“Get ahold of yourself! Think rationally, you fool. We have to leave this place *now*. I assumed we were safe because this area had been cleared. But if there are passageways below, into the actual *dungeon*—”

There might be more monsters who’d climbed up. Or other things. Watching them. Olesm’s blood ran cold. He nodded silently and he and Pisces made a rapid retreat back towards the top floor. Only when they were outside of the crypt and in the cold daylight did they feel safe enough to talk again.

“I can’t believe it. There was a passageway down there all along. And Calruz—”

“It is too early to assume he was the one who fell down there. I agree the evidence fits, but to assume his survival is going beyond the limits of speculation—”

“And why not? You know how people survive in those kinds of situations! They level under pressure! Haven’t you heard of adventurers surviving after being swallowed by monsters? Or—or going into dungeons and coming out months later and gaining ten, sometimes twenty levels!”

Olesm grabbed Pisces by the robes. The mage shrugged him off, looking troubled.

“Such cases do exist, I admit. But what would you do? Mount a rescue expedition? Into an area that is clearly inhabited by monsters and trapped? With who? The city would never agree, and the only other group with a vested interest in Calruz’s life is—”

“Yours.”

The Horns of Hammerad. Olesm stared at Pisces. The mage didn’t meet his eyes.

“You know what Ceria would do if she thought Calruz was alive. Yvlon, too.”

“I am well aware. But that would most likely be suicide.”

“Even so! If you could convince another group to help you, the Halfseekers for instance—”

“I think they have had enough of volunteering themselves for others, especially after what happened at Miss Solstice’s inn. Don’t you?”

The Human and Drake stood together in the snow, staring at each other. Olesm’s tail drooped. He couldn’t argue with that. He turned to look back towards the crypt’s opening.

“But if he is alive...”

“If. There is too much to risk for an uncertainty. Too much to lose for an outcome that most likely does not exist.”

That too was true. And yet, Olesm couldn’t push the thought out of his head. He stared challengingly at Pisces.

“If there’s even a chance, Ceria should know about it. She deserves to know.”

“Does she? Or would it bring her needless worry and heartbreak?”

Another fair point. The Drake didn’t know. He felt strongly, but Pisces was speaking sense as well. He didn’t know what to do. Olesm stared at Pisces.

“Do you really think it would be best to keep it secret? Really? Just not tell anyone, like that?”

At last, the mage hesitated. He looked at Olesm, and then turned away. When he spoke, it was slowly, haltingly.

“Sometimes...sometimes it is best to keep secrets, painful though it may be. Because the truth, however liberating, can be too much to bear. Freedom demands a terrible price, Olesm.”

The truth of that was reflected in Pisces’ stance, the pain in his face and voice. Olesm looked at him, and nodded slowly.

“You may be right.”

Pisces turned back to him. Olesm hesitated. He withdrew the file he’d received from the Adventurer’s Guild and then slowly handed it to Pisces. The mage blinked at it. Olesm took a breath.

“You know Ceria better than I do. You know the secret. If you think it’s worth telling her, telling the others, do it. If not...you can give that back to Maviss.”

Pisces stared at him. Olesm looked into his eyes and slowly nodded.

“It’s your choice. You know Ceria best.”

Then he turned and slowly began walking back to Liscor.

Some things were predictable. True, chance and the natural intermingling of cause and effect created a world in which unforeseen variables could lead to completely different outcomes, but it was still possible to predict what would happen to a relative degree of certainty. For instance, people were easy. Simple, even.

True, it was impossible to know each individual’s darkest secrets or the entire history that had culminated in the person who walked about today, but that didn’t matter. People were, in Pisces’ opinion, largely unimportant.

He could predict the way the vast majority reacted to a given set of stimuli. They were predictable. Sadly predictable.

He had seen it all the same, replayed ten thousand, a hundred thousand times across as many lives. People were the same. It was only their environment, culture, events, and species which acted as variables upon their templates. The masses were not sheep; rather, they were dough from which the same kinds of bread arose, occasionally different, but all alike in origin and purpose.

Only a few individuals stood out from the crowds, a few people who could not be predicted, who were worthy of note. Niers Astoragon was one of them. Erin Solstice another. And Olesm...Pisces had found someone else worthy of respect, of attention, today.

Because he had not predicted this. The [Mage] slowly walked back towards Erin's inn, paging through the file in his hand. It had been written by Drakes, in their species' script rather than the universal written language adopted across the world. No doubt another one of their security measures. But Pisces had taught himself their written language and so he could read it.

It said exactly what Olesm had told him. The possessions of adventurers recovered, a rough count of bodies separated by species, and nothing remotely resembling a Minotaur's corpse.

"It could be possible. But alive?"

That was not likely, Pisces knew. He had met Calruz briefly, and he had assessed the Minotaur as stubborn, arrogant, overly inclined towards violence, and obsessed with the idea of honor—typical of his species, in short. The odds of someone like that surviving any amount of time in a dungeon designed to eat such individuals was remote.

And yet, if he didn't tell Springwalker, then what? Pisces wandered into the Wandering Inn and realized it was occupied.

Sparsely occupied, but nevertheless inhabited by bodies. The Goblins were nowhere to be seen so they were probably in the basement. Instead, the two remaining adventuring groups were in the common room of the inn, right where Pisces had left them.

Ah, yes. He'd foreseen this as well. It appeared his teammates were still recovering from their expedition to the cave of roaches. Why they hadn't been ready to run when the wall of insects had swarmed them was beyond Pisces. He cautiously stepped into the room and heard Yvlon's voice. She was croaking; she'd thrown up numerous times after and during their mission.

"And then—and then they just came at us. All at once. They were in my armor, my hair, my mouth—I swallowed some of them."

"Oh my god."

Erin Solstice was there, holding Yvlon's hand, motioning Lyonette and Drassi over. They had buckets of hot water and soap. And blankets. Yvlon huddled in hers. Across the table, Ceria was sitting with Seborn, staring into her mug and shuddering. Jelaqua and Moore were wincing as Ceria continued the story.

"I thought we had them. I really did. I learned a poison spell just for this. You know, from my book. Poisoned snow, I thought it would kill them. But it just made them agitated. And then the big ones came out—"

Yvlon made a sound, and beside her, a large insect uncurled himself. Ksmvr raised his head, scratching at the bites on his carapace with one of his three arms.

"I thought I was the predator. Am I prey? Why did they attempt to eat me? Have I fallen so far down as to be food for food?"

“Aw, no, *no*, Ksmvr! Those are just dumb bugs. Come on, cheer up. I’ve got nice, hot food for you all as soon as Yvlon stops throwing up. And we’ll get you into fresh clothes, take you into Liscor for baths—just let Aunt Erin and Cousin Selys take care of you all.”

Cousin Selys? Pisces rolled his eyes as he saw everyone fussing around the rest of his team. Honestly. They were *bugs*. True, Pisces had [Flashstepped] out of the cave before they got him, but still.

No one was paying attention to him. Pisces settled down at a table to think. He sighed. To tell or not to tell? He could predict what Ceria would do. At least...what she’d probably do. She surprised him, sometimes. But in this?

What was the correct decision? Well, Pisces knew what he’d do. And yet, would Olesm honor his word? That seemed unlikely. The Drake was too impulsive. And part of Pisces also...

No. No, it was foolish. Pisces scrubbed at his hair, dislodging some insect shells and dandruff. Something hiding under the table snatched one of the wings that floated down with a paw. Pisces jumped, and saw Mrsha stuff a large beetle wing into her mouth and spit it out quickly.

“Hello?”

He stared. The young Gnoll stared up at him. Pisces hadn’t interacted with Mrsha much, although she was good at cleaning unwanted food from his plate and distracting others. He gestured towards the group sitting in the middle of the room.

“I believe you will find more entertainment with Miss Solstice. Over there.”

Mrsha turned her head towards Erin. The [Innkeeper] did indeed have plates of hot food she was trying to tempt Yvlon and the others with. But for

once, the Gnoll didn't bite, figuratively or literally. Her eyes narrowed as she stared at Erin and her ears flattened. Pisces frowned.

"Odd."

Why was Mrsha upset with Erin—ah, the Goblins. Of course. The Gnoll prowled around Pisces and he felt a hand searching at his belt and pockets. He slapped it away. But Mrsha had learned long ago that respecting personal boundaries was not a winning move and so she kept bothering him.

"Shoo."

He flicked his fingers and a bit of water sprayed her. Mrsha wrinkled her nose and jabbed a claw into Pisces' leg. He muffled a shout and clapped at his leg. She danced away.

Now would telling Erin to drag Mrsha away help or not? No, she'd probably yell at her and ineffectually deal with Mrsha. Or Lyonette would. The best solution was bribery. Pisces rummaged around at his belt and pulled something out. Yes, this would do.

"Here."

He handed her his wand. He'd forgotten to use it during the battle with the roaches. Again. Habit and years of practice had made Pisces accustomed to casting with his hands. And of course, it was a feasible option in combat, despite the ridicule it attracted from other mages—Ceria herself had proven that a mage's hands were a decent catalyst for low-level spells.

If Pisces used the simple spells he'd mastered in conjunction with his rapier, he could act as a strong combatant while his creations fought. However, if it were possible to expand his quick spellcasting with the wand to allow him to use Tier 3 or Tier 4 spells while fighting with his rapier—

Mrsha was curiously inspecting the wand. She knew what it was, of course; she wasn't an idiot, just mute. She banged it experimentally on the table, waved it in the air, and poked Pisces with it. He didn't care; the wand was too sturdy to break easily, no matter what she did.

And then Mrsha raised the wand to point towards her. She stuck the tip in her mouth and began to chew on it. *That* was unpredicted. And concerning. Pisces grabbed for the wand. Mrsha leapt backwards and pulled it out of her mouth.

She blinked at him. Pisces blinked back. He lunged, and she sped away, dashing upstairs with her new toy in hand. He cursed as he rose to follow her; she couldn't do magic with it, but he wasn't about to donate a valuable magic item to Mrsha's toy fund. And if she lost it, what then?

"Pisces! Stop bullying Mrsha! And what's this about you running away while everyone else got bugged?"

On cue, Erin noticed Pisces and began to harangue him. He groaned internally. He opened his mouth, and turned to make some excuse, or point out Mrsha's theft.

He froze when he saw Ceria. The half-Elf had gotten up from her table, and was looking at him. Just looking. But it was without reproach, without anger. Ceria nodded at Pisces.

"You okay, Pisces? You had a few bad bites yourself. Do you need a healing potion?"

That was unexpected. Pisces stumbled over his words.

"I, ah—I believe I am fine, Springwalker. Ceria. I don't believe wasting a healing potion on my injuries is warranted at this moment."

She nodded.

“Good. Selys tells us you were at the Adventurer’s Guild. Your idea. Why didn’t you mention it to us? It’s not a bad one, although I can see why it wouldn’t work with the Drakes. But if we took the contract, we could let you use your creation while we pretended to work. Why not?”

It’s not a bad idea. Pisces stared at her. It was an echo of what Olesm had said. He hadn’t predicted that. And he hadn’t predicted this. He opened his mouth, coughed.

“I, uh, believe that is not necessary. I spoke with Olesm earlier this morning. He has agreed to let me work on his authority. The pay is quite acceptable.”

“Oh? Good for you.”

Ceria raised her eyebrows. Selys groaned.

“What? That idiot. I bet I’ll have to be the one to account for everything! Do you know how hard it is to count rat tails? And how disgusting that is?”

Pisces ignored her grouching. Selys would be the best one. And the most probable one. None of the other [Receptionists] would give him the time of day, but she at least was impartial, if rude. But his eyes were on Ceria.

The secret. Pisces had been so sure when he was arguing with Olesm earlier. But now, all his objections melted away, as they always did. He stared at Ceria and felt the urge to tell her.

“Pisces? You okay? You’re looking a bit sick. You’re not going to start throwing up like Yvlon now, are you?”

She smiled at him. Pisces wavered. Countless secrets pressed against his lips, begging to be spoken. So many things that mattered, that might change everything and nothing. For a moment he felt them all pressing at his mind, begging to be said. A thousand secrets. A thousand untold truths.

I ran away from home.

My father still thinks of me as nothing but a disappointment.

I am working on a new undead creation.

My [Fencer] class doesn't exist; I never wanted to level, so I never did.

Sometimes I wake up at night and miss what could have been between us.

I apprenticed myself to an ancient monster. For knowledge and power.

I know Erin and Ryoka are from a different world. And I know there are more like them.

I ate your extra helping of lasagna yesterday and let you think it was Ksmvr.

I reached Level 30 yesterday.

I'm sorry.

And more. The words crowded Pisces' mind. So many lies and terrible truths. Too many. And he had learned his lesson, so Pieces chose the easiest one to speak. He opened his mouth and let it out. One less burden, one less wall between his heart and the world. He looked at Ceria and sighed as he spoke.

"Calruz is alive."

Everyone stared at him. Pisces hesitated. He raised one finger.

"Probably. Possibly. I might have jumped to conclusions based on partial evidence."

He looked around the room, and then shrugged. He waited five seconds, and the shouting started.

As predicted.

Olesm made his way back to his small office in the building that was technically the city hall of Liscor, but was more often used as a place for fancy parties and gatherings. Only recently had it been used for meetings of Liscor's council. They normally didn't need to meet.

But Olesm had his place here, and he was present almost every day in the small cubicle he'd been allotted by the city. He liked it, actually. He had access to the city's records, a place to snooze if he was tired or just to practice chess. The place was seldom occupied. It was his private abode.

But he also had work to do here. Olesm groaned as he rubbed at his back and settled in his comfy chair. His head hurt from this morning's drinking, his bladder was full from Krshia's tea, and he was sweaty and wet at the same time from his little adventure with Pisces. He stank of crypt dust and fear.

But all of that was nothing compared to the secret in his heart. Calruz was alive. Or might be. The Horns of Hammerad might not have all ended with Ceria. And who knew? If he had survived, had other adventurers? Had more found their way into that secret passage? He'd have to double-check the numbers of deceased adventurers with the remains recovered, but of course, some had fled the crypts and others had been eaten. A full count would be tricky.

The Drake muttered to himself as he looked around his organized desk for the right files. He noticed a few more papers in the little basket he'd put out for people to put things in. More work. Olesm glumly paged through a few reports.

“Information request—approved. Latest sighting of Goblin Lord and assessment? Approved, of course. Why did they send this here?”

He irritably pulled out his enchanted quill and scribbled on the pages, adding a wax seal of approval. One of his jobs as [Tactician] was to look over anything that might reveal confidential or important Drake secrets to other races or other cities. That meant he had to authorize a lot of trivial stuff.

Yes, that was his job. Olesm absentmindedly pulled over a report and scanned it. How many Silver-rank teams in Liscor? Probably the Humans wanting to know how many teams they’d lost. Approved. He drizzled wax and stamped it with his seal impatiently.

Now this, this reminded him of what he really was. Unimportant. Olesm sighed. After his glorious letter from Niers—which had gotten wet—and all the things Ilvriss had said, it was important to ground himself in reality. He wasn’t a big deal. He had potential, of course; Olesm knew his worth, but he was also aware of his lack of influence, personal power, both in levels and possessions, and youth. He wasn’t a prodigy. He was barely smart.

Another report. This one about goats? Oh, the Eater Goats. Yes, approved. Celum had a right to know about monster attacks and migrations. Olesm glumly reached for the second-to-last paper.

Now, Pisces, he was talented. He’d already reached Level 30! True, Olesm was close to that himself, but Pisces was creating horrific, amazing Bone Horrors and he was an adventurer who was most definitely Gold-rank at this point. That was success. But what would Olesm be? After he hit Level 30, he’d still be stuck here. Doing nothing.

Another request. This one was from an individual. A Gold-rank team. Fancy that. Ylawes Byres, seeking confirmation that Yvlon Byres lived in the city? Obviously that was non-confidential. A brother seeking a sister. Or

a father? Olesm shrugged and scribbled a note informing the adventurer that Yvlon was in Liscor *and* Celum thanks to the magic door and noted her membership in the Horns of Hammerad.

Yes, he was a small-time paper pusher, but at least he could take the time to help out in small ways like that. Olesm stamped the wax, feeling a bit better. He reached for the last bit of paper, scanned it, stamped it, and leaned back in his chair.

Would Pisces tell Ceria? Olesm bet he would. Pisces was a good person, for all he acted like he wasn't. And he liked Ceria. They had been a couple.

Olesm paused as he stared at the ceiling. He put a claw over his face as his lips trembled. Ceria. He turned in his chair and closed his eyes bitterly. Sleep. That was all he needed. He was a worthless worm, but at least he could sleep. And then he'd have to go to Ilvriss and smile and—

The unhappy thoughts milling about in Olesm's head slowly receded. His breathing grew slower and his body relaxed. He drifted off—

[Tactician Level 28!]

[Skill – Rallying Presence Obtained!]

Olesm's eyes opened wide. The Drake shot out of his chair and punched at the ceiling. He shouted.

“Alright! Yes, yes, yes!”

He danced around in his small office, laughing happily until a thought struck him. Olesm paused, and then drooped.

“Aw. This means Wall Lord Ilvriss is going to make me drink again.”

He sighed, and headed for the door. Maybe this time he could get them to fill his mug with wine. Olesm liked wine.

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Happiness was a simple thing. It was a strong bed, comfortable food, and a hot drink. Or was it a comfortable bed, hot food and a strong drink?

Sometimes Zel forgot. He'd slept out in the open, through blizzards with not much more than a sleeping bag, or right behind the front lines as a battle continued into the night too many times to count. He was used to deprivation.

So why was he so grumpy waking up in the morning these days? He had a soft bed with *silk* sheets of all things, rooms heated with magic runes, and a breakfast that had been prepared by a [Chef]. But he didn't like it. Zel had grown used to waking up to the smell of pancakes cooking, walking downstairs and eating his food while a small white Gnoll peered at him over the table and stole scraps from his plate.

That was happiness. This? This was just a place where he lived at the moment. And yet, Zel knew it was his fault. He couldn't handle being under the same roof as the Goblins. Was he too old to change? Or perhaps he had taken the easy excuse. Living once again in Peslas' inn made it all too easy to leave.

Still, he'd miss this city. Zel sighed as he strode towards the city hall for another interminable meeting with Liscor's Council. Like any good soldier, he was there right when he was supposed to be—early, in fact. The other Drakes lacked military discipline. All except for one.

Ilvriss was reclining in one of the padded chairs he'd insisted be brought in, covering his eyes and rubbing at his forehead. He winced as Zel closed the door with a soft click.

“Shivertail, don’t think so loudly.”

“You’ve been drinking again.”

Zel looked disapprovingly at the Lord of the Wall. Ilvriss only shook his head.

“Incorrect. I hadn’t stopped since we last spoke.”

“That was yesterday.”

“What is your point, precisely?”

The other Drake opened one bloodshot eye. Zel shook his head.

“You have to stop this. I understand your grief, but giving in to it isn’t —”

“When I ask for your advice, Shivertail, I will *ask*.”

Ilvriss turned his head away and closed his eyes. The conversation ended abruptly. Zel sighed to himself, but the [General] didn’t try to continue speaking. What was the point? The Lord of the Wall had reached the end of his quest. He’d found who’d killed his lieutenant, Periss. Ryoka Griffin had told him.

Az’kerash. The [Necromancer]. The thought that he’d survived made Zel clench his fists together. He was a danger. Now he saw more fully the grand plan that had led him to meet Ryoka in the forest, and coincided with her being the target of undead assassins—for that was what they had surely been—in Liscor. Normally, the news would have Ilvriss alert and making plans to defend his beloved Walled City as well. But—

Zel looked over at Ilvriss. The Drake was slumped over in his chair, cradling his head. Gone was the disciplined, arrogant front the Wall Lord had worn at all times. The truth of Periss’ death might have been necessary,

but it had snuffed the burning fire in Ilvriss' heart and left only mourning. He had drunk himself into despondency.

“You truly did love her, it seems.”

The other Drake's head rose slowly, not looking at Zel.

“Love her? I would have married her if she didn't think it was beneath my station.”

That surprised Zel. He would have expected any other confession to come out of Ilvriss' mouth. He waited as Ilvriss went on, speaking slowly in the silent room.

“I couldn't believe she'd died. I thought that Runner girl had to have been an [Assassin], one of my enemies plotting against me. I could have believed that she had been killed to hurt me, to hurt my city. But as an accident? She just followed that Human and died because—because I ordered it? Over a petty incident?”

“It wasn't your fault.”

Empty words. Zel grimaced as he said them. Ilvriss' glance told him that everyone had said the same thing. The [General] tapped a claw on the table.

“What I mean to say is that her death matters, Ilvriss. We know who the enemy is.”

“Yes. The Necromancer. Holed up in a castle in the middle of nowhere, forming an undead army. Sending his...servants out to eliminate his enemies under disguises.”

Slowly, reassuringly, Ilvriss' brows came together. He shook his head and winced.

“Pieces, Shivertail. It feels as though I can see part of the spider’s web around me. I’d heard of freak deaths, the disappearance of a good friend—assassinations. All that is usual in our world, but now I think of every one and wonder...”

Zel nodded. Was it Az’kerash, weakening the Drakes? How long had his spies been moving? Looking at the history of Regrika Blackpaw, it truly did seem like she’d sprung out of nowhere a few years back. Everyone had a story of her past exploits, but send a [Message] spell to ask for the source of it and there was no record of her ever being born to the Blackpaw tribe, or of her growing up. He’d already begun to look into her travels and noticed the pattern of deaths or ‘accidents’ following her around.

“We have to spread the word. Carefully. Miss Ryoka Griffin’s life and the lives of other innocents are at risk if we do not keep the secret. Not to mention we might force the enemy into acting before we are ready.”

“Do not tell me my business, Shivertail. I will reach out to my allies. Which I have done. Subtly. But also do not presume to lecture me now. I am grieving.”

“Through the bottom of a mug?”

“If I must!”

The two Drakes glared at each other as Ilvriss half-rose out of his chair. The door opened. Olesm walked in, precisely on time, juggling a sheaf of papers.

“I’m sorry, am I late? I was just receiving the latest reports from the Mage’s Guild and the [Scribe] was delayed—”

“Not at all. In fact, no one else has turned up.”

Zel nodded to Ilvriss as Olesm hurried to a seat opposite the two Drakes. Olesm bobbed his head awkwardly to the two of them, looking

intimidated at being alone with two famous Drakes. Zel knew better than to try and strike up small chat; instead, he leaned over towards Ilvriss and hissed at him under his breath.

“At least keep him out of your drinking sessions. Some of these young Drakes work hard for the future of the city and don’t need you stepping on their tails and holding them back.”

“I care about the next generation, Shivertail. Don’t lecture me—and besides, we were celebrating young Swifttail. He reached Level 28 yesterday!”

“So soon? That’s impressive.”

“I have a mind to recommend his name when I return to Salazar. He’s wasted here, and if he joins that army of sellswords he’ll languish there as well.”

Zel grimaced at Ilvriss’ jab at Liscor’s army. He had been a close friend and student of General Sserys, former [General] of Liscor and leader of the famed mercenary army. He couldn’t deny that the army had suffered in the decades since then, but it felt disrespectful to his mentor’s memory to agree.

Changing the subject, he glanced at Olesm. The papers he was spreading out could only mean one thing.

“There’s news from Esthelm at last, Olesm?”

Olesm jumped and nearly dropped the papers he was spreading around.

“Yes sir! It came in just as I was checking this morning. I brought it here right away and sent Street Runners to gather the Council. I hope I wasn’t being presumptuous?”

Ilvriss smiled at Olesm and waved a languid claw.

“Not at all. I’m sure that General Shivertail appreciates your forward thinking and quick action, as do I. But tell us, what is the news? I don’t feel like waiting for the rest of the Council to drag themselves out of their beds.”

He and Zel exchanged a grimace. The Council in Liscor was made up of various Guild heads and what passed for politicians in the city, but given Liscor’s relative isolation, they were hardly a premier group of leaders. Liscor generally trusted to its natural geographical defenses and strong walls as well as its powerful army to deter threats, and hadn’t suffered a real crisis since the last Antinium War. Olesm nodded and glanced towards the windows.

“Zeara, that is to say, the Watch Captain, seems to be delayed. I think she got a report and is relaying it to Klbkch, that is to say, the representative of the Hive—”

He coughed, glancing anxiously towards Zel and Ilvriss. Zel suppressed any reaction and nodded mildly.

“I understand. If you don’t mind repeating the message, you can give us the short version now.”

“Certainly. To summarize, we finally received a message from Esthelm...a day and a half since the Goblin Lord was predicted to have passed by its walls. It seems that delay was unavoidable—every tail has been needed to tend to the wounded.”

The two Drakes exchanged a glance. Zel frowned.

“Dire news. But the fact that there *are* wounded seems to indicate they survived the Goblin Lord’s passing.”

“Yes sir. I have the full report here, but to summarize, the Goblin Lord assailed their walls with a portion of his force as his army marched by, was repulsed, and left Esthelm alone.”

“Intriguing. I wouldn’t have thought he’d leave any city standing, much less one as poorly defended as Esthelm.”

Ilvriss frowned as he accepted a parchment detailing the battle. Zel frowned at it, but nodded slowly.

“No, it falls with what Olesm predicted, Ilvriss. Esthelm’s citizens were ready to fight—nearly all of them have combat classes now, and the Antinium repaired their walls. Add that to the fact that there’s really not much for the Goblin Lord to take a second time, and it’s a fairly unappetizing target.”

Olesm nodded and coughed again.

“It, uh, seems that way, General Shivertail. However, Esthelm had to prove that it wasn’t going to be taken so easily. They had to fight off several waves of Goblins and make them pay for each foothold they established before the attacking force dispersed. The casualties…”

“A quarter dead and over half the population wounded in some way. I see.”

Zel closed his eyes, imagining the carnage. The Humans had held their city, kept it, but at a terrible price. He pushed the parchment back and looked at Ilvriss. The Drake was grimacing, rubbing at his temples.

“It seems we’ll have a quick meeting. There’s not much we can do but wait for reinforcements from Liscor’s army and the second suppression force to arrive. And that will take a week at least.”

“You’ll have to repeat that six ways before the Council’s reassured, sir.”

“I know.”

Zel grimaced and Ilvriss growled some very insulting words about ‘spineless slug-like lizards’ under his breath. Meetings with Liscor’s

Council were never easy. But then Zel smiled as he thought of his news.

“Well, perhaps the meeting will be long, but I will leave it to you and Ilvriss to sort out. And I must apologize in advance, because the Council probably will take a great deal of reassuring.”

“And why’s that? If you’re intending to leave, Shivertail—”

“I’m afraid that’s just it, Ilvriss. I received a letter earlier this day through Celum.”

“What?”

Ilvriss broke off his angry snapping at Zel. The [General] stood up, and smiled. He controlled the trembling in his claws and tail as he looked casually at Olesm, who was staring at him with wide eyes.

“Please explain it to the Council like this, Olesm. I’m leaving. I have a meeting with someone further north. I’ll be traveling to Celum, and then, hopefully, further north even than that. I’m aware of the dangers of the Goblin Lord and the Humans, but it’s a risk I’m willing to take.”

“*What?*”

Both Drakes shot to their feet. Well, Ilvriss. Olesm had already been standing. The Wall Lord stared at Zel in disbelief.

“If you go north, half of those damn Humans will interpret it as an act of war! A Drake [General] hasn’t gone past Liscor since—”

“The last Antinium War. I know.”

Zel looked around the room calmly. He glanced towards the door and saw it open. Watch Captain Zevara strode in, looking breathless. She saluted as she saw Zel Shivertail.

“General Shivertail, I apologize for my delay. Is—is the rest of the Council not here yet?”

She looked incredulous and disgusted.

“I’ll send guardsmen to rouse them at once. My apologies—”

“Thank you, Watch Captain Zevara. But please, you might want to wait a moment. I was just telling the others that I was leaving the city.”

“Leaving the—”

Zel Shivertail smiled and straightened. The other Drakes were staring at him, and his heart was pounding wildly. But now he’d said it. It was too late to turn his tail and make another choice. He looked around the room.

“I’m going. Don’t worry Ilvriss; I’m still concerned with the Goblin Lord’s threat and—other matters. But I’m going to tackle it my way. I’m going north. To meet with someone.”

The room was silent. Ilvriss stared at Zel, and his eyes slowly narrowed.

“Who?”

The Drake [General] grinned at the Lord of the Wall as if he were two decades younger. Zel turned and strode out of the room without replying. The room was silent for two thundering heartbeats after he’d closed the door, and then all three Drakes charged after him. But it was too late. Zel was already running for the gates.

In Liscor, a Drake [General] ran towards an inn and reappeared in a Human city nearly a hundred miles north in moments. That was a small miracle of transportation. However, once in Celum, Zel Shivertail’s ability

to travel would be severely reduced. No other city had magical doors from a bygone era lying about, and if he wanted to travel with magic, Zel would find his options severely limited.

If you wanted to move fast, you had a few very improbable choices available to you. It was, in theory, possible to teleport people hundreds or thousands of miles, but only a few very high-level mages could do that. In fact, the most common use of teleportation was sending hand-sized parcels from one continent to another. That was the limit of most mages' abilities. If you wanted to teleport a person from Chandrar to Terandria, for example, you'd need a group of skilled [Mages]. Or an Archmage.

And if you didn't have access to that many mages, there were only limited and ancient scrolls or magical artifacts that could help you. Scrolls of long distance teleportation were rarer than moon diamonds, however, and not to be used lightly. A powerful kingdom might hoard such artifacts for the most important of circumstances for generations.

So if there wasn't magic, how else could one travel? By horseback? Wagon? By air? It was true that there were species that could fly, like the Garuda in Chandrar, but such travel was dangerous and highly impractical for other species. As for horses—yes, a [Rider] with high levels could travel at speed, and a [Caravaneer] might possess Skills that allowed him to travel at faster speeds, but the stark truth of it was that the size of Izril and indeed, the world, meant that travelling across a continent took weeks or months.

To move faster was an impossibility for almost everyone. Even famous [Mages] and celebrities would travel by carriage, where levels and magical wheels would allow them to reach up to a hundred miles per day. That was the limit of this world. Few could move faster. No one. Why, you'd need a Pegasus to go faster, and they were all extinct! You'd have to ride a Dragon's back, or cast the [Fly] spell. Or ride a magical carriage.

Far to the north of Celum, hundreds of miles north in fact, a bright pink carriage shot down a small road meant for foot travel. The carriage was large, grandly ornamented with gold and careful woodwork embellished by some long-dead master carpenter, and now, casually painted over with eye-searing pink. Four misty, semi-translucent horses pulled the carriage, running faster than any living horse in existence.

The carriage barreled down the dirt path, weaving to follow the curving road, almost soundless thanks to the magic enchanting it. And there was a lot of magic on the carriage. Without it, the vehicle would never have survived the speed of the journey, or managed to turn as nimbly as it did in response to the driver's movements.

A young man wheeling a handcart was heading down the road in the opposite direction, pushing a few sacks of produce or something else ahead of him and not looking where he was going. Why should he? Aside from monsters, bandits, or the uncertain nature of causality, he was perfectly safe. After all, there were no such thing as cars in this world.

The magical carriage drifted around a bend in the dirt road, shooting out behind a line of trees, a blur of pink death. The young man had only a moment to look up and see it coming at him, faster than thought. He put up his hands and screamed his last words—

Seconds after the carriage had shot past him, moving off the road for a split-second and continuing its mad course across the countryside. The young man stood where he was, frozen in fear. He would later abandon his cart and suffer recurring nightmares and maintain a distinct aversion to all things pink for years afterwards. But he was only one obstacle in the road, one skillfully avoided by the magical carriage's driver.

And it was notable that this famed carriage, belonging to none other than Magnolia Reinhart, did *not* routinely run over pedestrians. In fact, it was known for only being decorated with the blood of bandits or monsters.

Aside from the heart-stopping fright it generated, people who had seen it travelling reasoned it was safe. After all, who would be so foolish as to enchant a coach to move that fast and *not* give it the ability to avoid collisions?

“Blood on my grave, that was *close*.”

Reynold muttered to himself as he turned the coach down the road, shooting past a quiet village. The world blurred around him, and the freezing wind blew hard at him as he sat on the driver’s seat of Magnolia’s pink carriage. Only the magical enchantments kept him from shivering in his butler’s uniform.

“Reynold? We’ve slowed. Is everything alright?”

A voice came from the carriage behind him, and the sliding panel connecting him to the interior slid open a fraction. Reynold coughed and raised his voice to be heard.

“My apologies Lady Reinhart. We’re passing by a village and I must navigate us over a river.”

“Ah, bridges. How tiring. Thank you, I completely understand.”

The panel slid shut. Reynold didn’t have to look behind him to know that it had been Ressa who’d both opened the panel and closed it. The silent [Head Maid] who accompanied her mistress everywhere was as quiet as a falling leaf when she wanted to be. In fact, she could be right behind him and Reynold wouldn’t notice. It had happened before.

Part of Reynold wanted to turn his head, but he didn’t dare look away as he guided the coach over a small footbridge that left bare inches on either

side for the wheels—all at a speed a bit faster than Ryoka could run. The horses and, indeed, wheels of the carriage turned precisely as he adjusted the reins in his hand—moving as much from his mental orders as his physical motions.

Reynold cleared the bridge, scanned the road quickly, and accelerated to a velocity that would have left the average unladen swallow, European or otherwise, far behind in the dust. The world blurred into a tunnel once again and Reynold could only trust to his Skills and his reflexes to spot obstacles on the road ahead.

“Reynold?”

The panel slid open as Reynold guided the carriage out of the forest and upwards towards a hill. He cursed as he spotted rocky terrain ahead and whispered a word.

“[Flying Wheels]—yes, Lady Reinhart?”

“I have some *delightful* pastries here, and Ressa tells me I’m not allowed to eat them all in one sitting. Would you like one?”

The carriage’s wheels rose off the ground and shot over the rocks in front of them, climbing effortlessly as Reynold tried to find the best incline that wouldn’t send them crashing into the hillside. His knuckles were white on the reins as he sent the coach upwards at dizzying speeds, but his voice was level and only a bit high-pitched as he replied.

“You are most kind Lady Reinhart, but I, ah, am quite satisfied at the moment. Thank you.”

“A pity. Ressa will have to eat them I suppose, or my other guests. Oh, we are travelling upwards, aren’t we? Reynold, make us fly, won’t you? I do enjoy that.”

“Yes, Lady Reinhart.”

Reynold nearly screamed. Instead of decelerating as he crested the top of the hill, he willed the carriage to go faster. The pink coach shot over the top of the hill and *flew* through the air for several heart-stopping seconds. Reynold heard a delighted laugh from the carriage behind him as he spoke a hurried word, activating another enchantment.

“[Featherfall]. [*Featherfall*]!”

Slowly, he saw the world approaching below him. Reynold jerked the reins and the coach smoothly turned left, avoiding a rock and a lake, returning to ground, and finding the road again. He breathed a sigh of relief, and then spoke another word.

“[Grounded Wheels].”

There was a slight rumble and increased traction as the wheels met solid earth again. Now they were on a straightaway headed through some flat, lovely, *open* plains. Reynold could have cried in relief. He turned, and nearly jumped out of his skin as he saw Ressa standing next to him. The [Maid] had climbed *out* of the carriage’s door and to the front without him hearing a thing.

“Reynold.”

“Yes, Miss Ressa?”

Reynold’s eyes jerked ahead of him as Ressa’s low voice spoke in his ears. The [Maid] eyed the road ahead and nodded to the magical horses pulling them ever faster.

“Don’t use the [Flying Wheels] enchantment if Lady Magnolia asks again. It wastes magical energy and we don’t have time to spend recharging the mana stones more than necessary.”

“Yes, Miss Ressa.”

“Spoilsport!”

An indignant voice called from within. Reynold breathed a sigh of relief as Ressa turned and pulled herself back into the carriage. He heard them talking for a second.

“We’re close to our destination. It looks like thirty minutes more.”

“Excellent. I’m tired of sitting and I could use a chance to stretch my legs before the next trip. Also, I’d like lunch.”

“It should be ready by the time we arrive. Without tea, this time. You don’t need to have that much sugar and we don’t have time to stop and let you pee every fifteen minutes.”

“*That* was a poor batch of tea, Ressa. Honestly, it happened once.”

“And it won’t happen again.”

The panel slid shut and Reynold breathed a sigh of relief. He guided the carriage onwards, spraying mud and snow as he travelled across the countryside. Not the roads—even in winter, colliding with an errant traveler was too likely. He kept his head scanning the horizon for threats, points of interest, and to make sure he was going the right way.

This was his job. He was a [Butler], one of the many servants in the Reinhart employ. But he was also one of Lady Magnolia’s personal aides, which meant that he had...other...competencies. One of them was driving this carriage.

No one else could do it at this speed, which is why Reynold had driven north to escort Lady Magnolia wherever she needed to go. Also, Reynold was a long-time servant to Lady Magnolia, and Ressa had personally approved his ability to be discreet in all situations. That was a very important quality to have, Reynold knew. Lady Magnolia’s bathroom habits were the least of the secrets he sometimes heard.

The carriage eventually drew close to a large city, and Reynold was relieved to finally slow to something less than death-speed. However, he didn't have the luxury of driving into the city and being forced to obey the speed of local traffic—no, Magnolia Reinhart was far too busy for that.

She had an estate on the outskirts of this city. She had estates everywhere, but this one was rather small and not meant as a place for her to stay in. Rather, a delegation of [Maids] and other servants was already waiting for the carriage as Reynold stopped it in the middle of the frozen road outside the villa.

“Are we here? Good!”

The door opened and Magnolia hopped out before Ressa or Reynold could open the door or lower the half-step. Magnolia stretched and Reynold carefully dismounted as well, surreptitiously stretching his tense lower back as Ressa emerged.

“Food, fuel. Reynold will handle it. Now, are Lady Bethal and the Chevalier Thomast here? I trust they are being entertained.”

Frightened servants parted like a wave before her, and both women strode into the villa. Reynold sagged for a moment, and then waved at one of the [Maids] hurrying towards him at the head of a small procession. He knew her; his job meant he was acquainted with most of Magnolia's staff.

“Janica, greetings. Tell me that's hot bacon I keep smelling? I'm half frozen and I could use a bite to eat. And I think the mana stones on the coach need replacing.”

“You can have it on the road! Not now, you glutton! You need to show me and the others how to replace the stones—I can't remember how and you're the only expert.”

The [Maid], Janica, slapped Reynold's hands away from the basket she was holding. The other servants nodded to Reynold deferentially—he outranked them all as one of Magnolia's special [Butlers]. The [Manservants], [Porters], and generic [Servants] descended on the coach. Reynold sighed as he walked around to the back of the carriage and pulled out a large key. He unlatched a hidden compartment on the back and turned to Janica. She was an older woman with grey hair, but she peered keenly inside the inner workings of the carriage as if she were a girl seeing her first artifact.

“It always amazes me to see how it works! You say an Archmage invented this?”

“Apparently. It's all runes and spellcraft to me, but here's where the mana stones go. Hold on, are these all certified to have the maximum charge?”

The large, hand-sized gems presented to Reynold on a soft pillow were some of the most expensive objects in the world. He tiredly grabbed them and popped the ones in the carriage out of their sockets with an experienced hand. The [Porter] with the pillow trembled as Reynold placed two of the nearly spent mana stones on the pillow. One was a ruby, the other one a perfectly cut emerald.

The process that turned perfect gemstones into vessels for magic made them expensive enough that Gold-rank Adventurers could only afford the smallest of them. The ones that Magnolia Reinhart used for her carriage were beyond the pay grade of most Named Adventurers.

“Have them replenished at the Mage's Guild. Don't worry; they know how to do it, although I suspect it will take them a week or more. And these ones will last half a day if I keep travelling. Janica, take pity on me. I'd rather not eat and drive at the same time if I can help it.”

The elderly [Maid] was supervising the loading of the carriage. Reynold could see [Maids] carefully cleaning out any trace of dust or crumbs as platters and neatly-wrapped baskets were placed in the storage compartments above and below where passengers could sit. He coughed.

“Put the written reports under the table. Just there. There’s a compartment. It slides out—hold on, I’ll do it.”

He clambered into the carriage and showed the others where to load some of the supplies. While it was true that Magnolia’s personal carriage ran on mana stones, Reynold personally thought that it ran on two other things as well: food and information.

“You think she’ll have a chance to read all of this while she speaks with her guests?”

Janica frowned as she straightened a pile of papers before placing it inside the hidden drawer under the table in the center of the carriage. Reynold nodded.

“I believe Ressa will pull it out in the first fifteen minutes. You do know that Lady Reinhart eats and catches up with all her informants from here, don’t you?”

“I do...but it’s hardly what one expects of her. I mean, she could spend an hour or two in the villa—”

Reynold shook his head.

“She’d never waste time that way. We can be a hundred miles from here in an hour. Now, about the food?”

The [Maid] sighed.

“Oh, you. Here. Bacon-wrapped pork loin. Careful with the wrapping—you don’t want to get grease on your suit.”

The [Butler] could have cried as she presented him with a piping-hot delicacy. He did indeed take exquisite care to eat it while gripping the wrapping paper tightly, and to Janica's disapproval, he scarfed it down in minutes.

"Honestly! Do you know how long our [Cook] worked on that, especially when it was requested specially by Lady Reinhart? You should consider yourself privileged that she's thinking of you, ordering such greasy fare—"

"As I recall, she wanted it for *herself*, Janica. Is that fresh bread I see? And is there a chance for a drink?"

"What do you think? Here, I've hot spiced wine—"

"No wine."

"Excuse me?"

She looked taken aback. Reynold smiled at her apologetically.

"I can't drink while driving."

"What, not a drop?"

"It makes me slower to react. I'll have hot milk if you have any. Hot water, otherwise."

"I'd be a poor [Maid] indeed to let you go off with hot water! You there! Hot milk for Mister Reynold, and be quick about it! I want the coach buffed and polished by the time the [Ladies] return."

Reynold grimaced.

"Don't bother with that. The first puddle we go through, it won't matter. And you don't have time for anything more than the milk I think; Lady Reinhart will be here in minutes, never mind her guest."

“What? Don’t be silly—”

Just as Reynold had predicted, he barely got a hot flask filled with goat’s milk before Lady Magnolia was striding out of the villa, followed by Lady Bethal and the elegant Chevalier Thomast at her side. Forewarned by Reynold, the other servants were standing at attention and the carriage was ready to go. The [Butler] was already in the driver’s seat.

“Ah, thank you Reynold. Lady Bethal, I’m sure you’ve met my driver before?”

“I have! Reynold, is it? Good day to you, sir. I trust Magnolia isn’t keeping you too busy, what with how she’s been travelling across the continent?”

Lady Bethal was all smiles and delicacy—when she wasn’t thorns and fury. Reynold bobbed his head to her politely, recalling the stories of her famous Rose Knights. Thomast nodded to Reynold but remained silent as ever.

“It’s my privilege to serve Lady Reinhart and you, Lady Bethal. If there is anything I can do, please do not hesitate to ask.”

“Oh, but he is well trained, isn’t he? I could just steal him away to be one of my personal attendants, Magnolia! Perhaps I will!”

Magnolia’s lips quirked up in a smile as Bethal let Thomast help her up into the carriage.

“He is. Well-trained, that is. I’d take it amiss if you stole him, Bethal. He’s one of the few servants I can rely on, the only one who can get me where I want to go fast enough.”

“You say that about *all* of your servants, Magnolia. But I want a [Butler] who can keep up with me! You seem to have monopolized all the best ones.”

“All the ones with interesting talents, at least. My advice is to train them to be [Butlers], not train [Butlers] to be interesting. Now, let us be off. Reynold, I need you to drop Bethal off by the village of Neunham. You know, the one that was raided by Goblins yesterday? If you need a map, I think we have one. Ressa, where are the maps?”

“There is no need, Lady Reinhart. I know the way. We will be there in about two hours by my rough estimation.”

“Excellent.”

The door slammed shut. Janica barely had time to bow with the other servants before Reynold accelerated the coach out of the villa’s gates and into the snowy plains again. He sipped from his canteen, feeling the warmth in his cold body. With one hand, Reynold put down the canteen and fished around in the wrapped basket next to him. He felt something warm and pulled it up, sniffing at it.

“Hot rolls? With butter? You are a lifesaver, Janica.”

He ate, carefully guiding the coach onwards. It was cold outside, and the food kept him feeling alive. Inside, he could hear the muted buzz of conversation. Ironically, for all the enchantments, there wasn’t a spell of silence within the coach, so Reynold could pick out bits of conversation.

“...had my Rose Knights head out two days ago, and I sent them a [Message] spell to gather at that village. Of course, I hardly want to camp out longer than necessary, so I was relieved you were picking me up.”

That was Lady Bethal. Reynold listened with half an ear as he drove westward and south. One of the things that made him a capable driver was his knowledge of the continent. He could plot a route to Neunham in his head. He heard Lady Magnolia laugh lightly and reply, sounding slightly muffled.

“It is the least I can do, Bethal. Especially since you’re doing me a favor and sorting out that problem. But you don’t have to go with your knights in person.”

“Nonsense! If I’m not there, how will I know if they’ve done their jobs? Besides, it is a mission of gallantry and I wouldn’t pass up the opportunity to see my Thomast fight for anything.”

“As you wish. I have to attend to business, but I will send a carriage to pick you up whenever you are done. Please do stay in touch via [Message] spell, won’t you?”

“Very well. But isn’t that large army you’ve gathered north of here? I’d have thought you would have stayed north to lead them towards the Goblin Lord.”

“I hardly feel the need to lead an army myself. That’s what officers are for. The soldiers are heading this way on their own. I’ll meet them when they arrive, and I have business in Invrilil...”

“Oh? What about?”

“Hmm. I had a report from one of my servants that troubles me. Ressa, do pull out the reports. Anything from Sacra?”

Sacra? Reynold frowned. He knew Sacra—she was one of Magnolia’s special servants, like him. Only her specialty was undercover work. She’d trailed Ryoka back in Invrilil and he hadn’t seen her in the mansion after that, so he’d assumed she was carrying out one of Lady Reinhart’s requests. She was very good both in combat and in disguising herself; she’d been furious that Ryoka had managed to identify her so easily.

“Nothing else, Lady Reinhart. Although there is a report about the, ah, adventuring group you’re patronizing and Esthelm—”

“*Esthelm*? Dead gods Ressa, forget the children. Tell me, is the city standing?”

“Barely. It seems the Goblin Lord was repulsed a day and a half ago, but casualties are high...”

“Send gold and more help through Celum if possible, and add that to my list of things to discuss with Liscor’s Council. I will have to do that today—ah, how infuriating. At least there is the door. Bethal, have you heard about this? Some adventurers found a magical *door* of all things, and you’ll never guess what it does. It teleports people, so they somehow managed to create a link between Celum and Liscor—”

“My word! And the Drakes allowed it?”

“I don’t believe they had a choice. It’s in an inn, you see, just outside of the city—”

“Miss Erin.”

Reynold mumbled to himself around another mouthful of bread. He nearly choked and washed the food down with milk. He drove on, half-listening as the voices talked on of plans. But in time, he stopped listening. There were some things he preferred not to know as a butler, and the rushing world around him was peaceful. Reynold sat as the wind howled silently outside of the carriage, feeling the cold around him, hovering on that delightful edge where warmth and cold made him appreciate every layer he had on.

He felt alive.

An hour and a half later, Reynold slowed and Lady Bethal and Thomast left the carriage in front of a village that had clearly seen fighting. Reynold knew combat, and he could see a story in the way the gates had been smashed open. But there was even more of a story in the dead bodies hanging from the roofs of houses. The villagers had managed to cut some down, but a few bodies remained and the ropes showed how many had been there.

“Troubling. I hope Bethal can sort it out.”

Magnolia murmured to herself as she stared into the village with angry eyes. Ressa looked at her.

“You doubt she can?”

“I think she might grow bored if she can’t find the attackers within the next few days. If she does, they die. If not, we add this group to the list of targets. Reynold, take us away. To Invril.”

The [Butler] had been staring at the carnage and remembering the past. He broke out of his trance and grabbed the reins.

“At once, Lady Magnolia.”

Invril was a hop and a skip away from Neunham in terms of distance, but the journey was extremely taxing given how many people filled the roads even in the winter, even with Goblins about. Reynold had to slow the coach and work hard on avoiding hitting anything. His driver’s job was mentally and physically exhausting, and so he was very, very grateful when he sped into the grounds of Lady Magnolia’s mansion.

“We’re back!”

Magnolia was all smiles as she walked up the stairs to her estate. There was no welcoming line of bowing servants as was customary in the main Reinhart estate; Magnolia and Ressa were of the opinion that it wasted time for everyone involved, and was particularly unkind in the cold weather.

Reynold parked the carriage in the stables, rubbing his hands together as the cold caught up with him. He hurried through the back entrance and found one of the stable boys waiting.

“I think the mana stones need replacing, Jefry. They’re fairly new, but if Lady Reinhart has me driving about, I don’t want to have to rely on the spares or hope that we pass by one of her estates.”

“I’m on it.”

The young boy slipped into the cold without fear of the chill, something which the older Reynold envied. He hurried further into the mansion, greeting maids, and heading towards the kitchens. He dearly wanted something hot to drink and something to snack on while he sat and rested. He was exhausted from driving; it took a high toll on his nerves.

He never got there. One of the [Maids] he knew well—a Gnoll named Bekia—was just whispering to him that Sacra had come galloping back towards the mansion with important news she dared not send by [Message] spell a week ago when he heard Magnolia’s voice echoing from her personal sitting room.

“There’s a *what* living on my continent!?”

Every servant in the halls winced and some ducked. Reynold and Bekia hovered closer to the door Magnolia was shouting from behind. They heard her voice and Sacra’s muffled reply.

“In a small village? *Riverfarm*? Where is *that*? How long ago—what’s this about Lady Rie? Why didn’t anyone mention—this morning? How long

ago?”

The door burst open. Reynold saw Lady Magnolia striding towards him, Sacra meekly following behind, and Ressa following back after both of them. Magnolia snapped at Reynold as he was bowing.

“To Lady Rie Valerund’s estate, Reynold. Quickly!”

Another trip. Reynold groaned inside, but raced out into the stables to get Jefry to prepare the carriage. In minutes he was driving out into the cold again. He hadn’t even gotten a chance to sit down.

“Here we are, Lady Magnolia.”

Reynold was cold and sore from sitting for so long, and very tired despite it being only just past midmorning. But he’d been driving since before dawn, so that was excusable. Magnolia burst out of her carriage and took one look around the destroyed town and then turned towards the mansion at the top of the hill.

“Damaged, but intact. I assume Lady Rie is alive. She had better be, or I will hold every adventurer here accountable.”

There was a large group of Silver and Gold-rank adventurers present, many still on horseback. They had prevented Reynold from getting any closer to the mansion, but as they turned and saw Lady Magnolia, they parted like the sea as she strode through the town.

Reynold followed, after finding a place to park the carriage. Sacra hopped down from the front. At least he’d had company on the drive here, and she’d caught him up with the incredible story of her undercover

mission to find out exactly who the stranger that Ryoka had met with was. Reynold could hardly believe it. An [Emperor]? Here?

“You’re sure he’s not some [Lord] or a—an [Earl] or something, right Sacra?”

She glared at him. The woman who called herself Odveig and pretended to be a simple Silver-rank adventurer looked completely different from the austere [Maid] dressed in her uniform who strode after Lady Magnolia. Her voice was waspish as she replied.

“I’m sure. I don’t make mistakes and it’s not like he concealed the fact, Reynold. And you met him as well—didn’t you feel he was special?”

“Yes, but, well, an *[Emperor]*? Truly?”

Reynold shook his head. He could remember the urge to bow before Laken Godart, but as for the rest...he picked up his pace as he heard Magnolia shout in front of him.

“Where is Lady Rie Valerund?”

Hands pointed. Magnolia strode up to the damaged double doors of the mansion. The enchanted wood that had held back hordes of Goblins parted in an instant before her. Reynold strode inside after her and saw a woman in a gown overseeing her servants. They were packing everything of value in the mansion.

“Lady Rie! A word.”

Magnolia walked towards her and the other [Lady] turned. Servants, curious adventurers, and the guards who had followed her froze in place. They couldn’t help it. Only Reynold, Sacra, Ressa, and Rie herself could move. Magnolia studied the preparations for flight and smiled at Lady Rie.

“My apologies, Lady Rie. I did not receive your message until just now. I am delighted to see you well, but what is all this? You are leaving?”

“Lady Reinhart.”

Rie’s voice was cool, but Reynold had met enough [Lords] and [Ladies] to tell that Lady Rie was pressured by Magnolia’s appearance in person. She was a low-level [Lady] and Magnolia was the biggest shark in the ocean. She gestured to the frozen people around her.

“I regret to say that I no longer consider my home safe after the Goblin attack. I would have been dead but for the intervention of a certain man. Have you, ah, heard of an individual known as Laken Godart?”

Lady Magnolia’s smile was sharp and bright.

“I have just now. I would *love* to hear about him. Why don’t we sit in what is left of your parlor and talk? Ressa, find us some chairs.”

She swept Lady Rie towards the parlor, and only now did the people around her find the ability to move their legs again. Ressa headed after the two [Ladies], but a man broke away from the crowd, seemingly determined to go after them.

“You there. Refrain from interrupting Lady Magnolia.”

Ressa interposed herself between the man and Magnolia in an instant. The big man, who was bald and wearing armor, slowed. He ducked his head.

“Pardon me, Miss, but I am Lady Rie’s Captain of the Guard. I should be with her if—”

He didn’t finish the thought, but left the rest unspoken. If Lady Magnolia, famed for her temper, decided to do something. The Reinharts were feared not only for their power, but for their role as arbiters and

enforcers of their law across the continent. Ressa frowned at him and looked towards Reynold and Sacra.

The two servants leapt into motion without a word. Reynold intercepted the Captain of the Guard, adroitly pivoting the big bald man out of Lady Magnolia's path before the man quite knew what was happening.

"Pardon me sir. May I know your name?"

"Uh, Gera. But I have to—"

"My apologies, Captain Gera. I am Reynold, a [Butler] in the employ of Lady Reinhart. I assure you that she intends only to speak with Lady Rie on a number of pressing matters. Such discussions are best left to the nobility, however, without personal interference."

"But I—"

"Why don't you sit here, Sir?"

Sacra didn't quite kick the legs out from under Gera, but he found himself sitting, and, suddenly, holding a cup of tea. Reynold and Sacra hovered around him, and the [Maid] whispered to Reynold.

"Reynold, I have to go to Lady Reinhart. She'll probably want my opinion. Can you handle him?"

He nodded and Sacra briskly stepped into the mansion. The big man, Gera, bit his lip.

"I should be at Lady Rie's side."

"Surely not for a simple discussion, sir?"

Gera hesitated.

"She and Lady Magnolia are uh—I'm sure Lady Reinhart is well thought of, but Lady Rie is a bit—bit—"

Frightened of her. And for good reason. But you'd only cause more trouble, going in. Reynold bit his tongue on the rest of the words and smiled politely.

"I am sure Lady Rie will rise to the occasion, Captain Geram. But while I have you, may I ask what transpired here? I see you have fought off an attack. Was this all the doing of Goblins?"

"Goblins? Uh—yes. Yes they were. We would have been got by them surely as I'm sitting here, if not for Emperor Laken."

Emperor Laken. Reynold winced internally. Lady Magnolia would *not* be happy about that. And true enough, she wasn't. In fact, she began shouting.

It took some doing to restrain Geram—Reynold succeeded mainly by getting the man to have a drink and telling him that if he *did* interfere, Magnolia Reinhart would put him into a box and leave him there. Whether in pieces or intact would probably depend on her worsening mood.

After about an hour's time, someone came out of the parlor and headed straight for Reynold as he was miserably drinking water while Geram slowly finished a third cup of strong spirits. Reynold stood up at once as Ressa approached him. The [Head Maid] was holding a [Message] scroll and scowling, which never boded well.

"Miss Ressa, is something amiss?"

She nodded curtly.

"We have a problem, Reynold. You will have to take the carriage and head south. Towards Celum."

Celum? If it hadn't been for his [Butler] class, Reynold would have groaned aloud. That was a day's journey and a hard drive even if he was

full of energy, which he was not. He was hungry, cold, tired, and his butt hurt. But Ressa was clearly impatient. He hesitated.

“Am I to understand that I will leave you and Lady Magnolia behind?”

“That’s correct. We will send for another form of transport and make the journey back to Invril where we will await you.”

Reynold frowned.

“But surely we could send the other carriage—”

Magnolia Reinhart possessed two magical carriages, where most kingdoms didn’t have one. Her personal carriage was maintained at all costs; the other one was powerful, but often suffered from a lack of resources and [Mages] of the caliber needed to fix it. Either one was far, far faster than any other form of transport, however, which is why he was surprised he had to take Magnolia’s personal carriage. But Ressa just shook her head.

“The other carriage refuses to start. There must be something wrong with the enchantments.”

The [Butler]’s heart sank.

“Again? I could drive back and see if I could—”

“No. The carriage was supposed to pick up a very important guest. You need to drive to Celum and pick up the traveler—he will be waiting with a red cloak and you will recognize him on sight.”

“Yes, Miss Ressa. But the trip will take hours. I won’t be back until late in the night and I’ve been driving since this morning. I am...slightly exhausted, Miss Ressa.”

He knew complaining to Ressa was a dangerous idea, but Reynold had to say it. He hesitated as the [Head Maid] glared at him and pushed his luck

further.

“Could I not drive back to the estate and switch drivers? I believe it would not take—”

“Reynold.”

She stared at him and Reynold shut up. Ressa shook her head briskly.

“No. The carriage should have left *this morning*, and I was not informed until now.”

She gritted her teeth and Reynold cringed and knew that heads would roll when they returned to the mansion. Ressa went on.

“Our guest requires the fastest driver to get him here. Time is of the essence, and the route goes past the area where the Goblin Lord is said to be marching.”

That was true, too. Reynold knew he was the best driver for the job, but the world was swimming and he was just a bit angry. He tried one last time.

“Miss Ressa, I understand, but my condition now—”

Ressa looked at him, and put a hand on Reynold’s arm. She didn’t grip his arm or pull out one of the daggers he knew she carried. It was a soft touch, and so intimate and unlike her that Reynold froze in an instant. Ressa looked into his eyes and lowered her voice.

“Reynold. This is *important*.”

He fell silent, and realized Ressa was telling him that there was no time to argue, or even switch drivers. After all, the next best driver was Alkran, and he had broken his arm when the assassins had attacked. It still hadn’t healed properly. So Reynold straightened and nodded.

“Please forgive me, Miss Ressa. I will return at all speed.”

“Good. Go. And Reynold—please hurry.”

He had seldom heard Ressa use that tone. Reynold turned and *ran* for the carriage. In less than a minute he was on the road, and driving as fast as he could. But even going as fast as he dared, it would be six hours to Celum. Well, maybe five if he drove fast enough to *really* be dangerous.

He did. He drove for hours, until he came across the Goblin Lord’s army. They swept across the landscape like a horde of green locusts, burning and destroying anything without walls in front of them. Reynold drove wide of them, until he saw the people.

This is the despair of [Butlers], the despair of the man who sees all and can do so little. Reynold knew it. He was not a powerful man; he was a servant in the employ of a powerful woman. But he could do little more than assist her. That was his role.

So why did he have to see this? The carriage slowed as he saw the scene. It was the same scene you saw on battlefields, from the safety of your home. It was the scene that was universal and yet always unique.

It was tragedy.

They were refugees perhaps, a village that had evacuated in the face of the Goblin Lord’s armies. But this one had moved too slowly, or the Goblins had moved too fast. Whatever the case, the wagons and stream of villagers had been caught by a group of Goblins.

Not just a group. The advance force of the Goblin Lord’s army. Reynold had driven to avoid them, but the Goblins were spread out in a huge wave going north. They filled the horizon, and Reynold shuddered as he’d driven

away from them. He was staring at war, a terrible army capable of sacking a city. How many Goblins were there? Tens of thousands.

And part of their force had decided to attack the villagers. A group of Goblins riding Shield Spiders rode ahead of a whooping mass of Goblins, charging at the villagers as they screamed and fled from their wagons, running towards the hills where they might find safety.

But too slowly. The Goblins were closing. Reynold saw it all as he drove past, and knew there was nothing he could do. Nothing. If he tried, he would surely be overwhelmed by the mass of Goblins. Running over a group of [Bandits] was one thing and dangerous enough, but this? There were hundreds of Goblins streaming towards the villagers and thousands more behind them. Tens of thousands behind them.

And yet, the villagers saw him. Some ran towards him, screaming and waving their hands, only to be cut down by arrows. Others were lifting children in their arms, turning, trying to get his attention. Reynold cursed them as he drove. Why were they stopping to get his attention when the Goblins were right on top of them?

“Run, run you idiots!”

It was too late either way. The Goblins were too close. They were already beginning to cut down the villagers from behind. Reynold saw it all so clearly. Even if they got to the hills, it was too late. Even if they had a lead, the Goblins would just track them down. It was too late to help, too late—

They were cutting down men and women, children. Laughing. The red eyes of the Goblins turned towards Reynold as he drove past them. Some loosed arrows, but he was going far too fast for them to ever hit him.

It was his duty. He couldn't risk the carriage or even himself, no matter what. Reynold tried to close his ears to the screaming. He told himself he

was doing his job. He was just a [Butler].

A [Combat Butler].

Reynold's carriage *crashed* into the first group of Goblins, scattering bodies. The ghostly horses trampled the Goblins in front of him to the ground; others bounced off the sides and front of the carriage. Reynold shouted as he drove towards one of the Goblins who looked like a leader. He was mounted on a Shield Spider. He snarled as Reynold unsheathed the sword he carried everywhere.

“[Sickle Cut]!”

A blade flashed and lightning crackled. Reynold's sword beheaded the Goblin and the electricity earthed itself on the Goblins around him. The [Butler] snarled as he drove into the Goblins and turned the carriage.

“Drive, *drive!*”

He'd lost momentum as he crashed into the Goblins, turning their advance party into a mass of broken bodies. The ghostly horses surged and Reynold felt the carriage regaining traction. The villagers were running, but the Goblins were right behind them. How much time could Reynold buy? A minute? Five?

One was too many. The Goblins were loosing arrows at him. Reynold dodged one and shouted.

“[Burst Speed]!”

The carriage shot out of the mass of Goblins, avoiding the rest of the arrows. Reynold turned the carriage. Not yet. He had to get their attention, buy time! He drove at the Goblins again and they scattered. But his control was precise. Reynold hit another group.

That's the way. Scatter them. He chopped downwards as he passed by a Hob and felt the shock of his sword cutting into bone. It was the same feeling as being on horseback, of charging the enemy.

He had been a soldier, once. Reynold shouted something as the blood thundered in his ears. He saw an arrow speeding at his chest and *twisted*. It cut across his side, a line of fire. More Goblins. They were everywhere. How long had it been?

Seconds. Reynold spun the carriage, throwing Goblins off as they tried to climb on. He rode the horses over a Hob as it tried to grab the carriage. A small Goblin landed on the roof and Reynold stabbed it, the electricity shocking the Goblin's skin, making it let go.

He had to get away. Circle for another charge. There were so many arrows—one hit Reynold's arm but glanced off the cloth. Bad shot. Another—hit him in the shoulder. Reynold pushed the horses and then saw something black flying at him from the left. He spun the coach and felt it *shudder* from the impact.

He'd run over Trolls and not felt anything. Reynold turned his head and saw part of the pink carriage's woodwork was *splintered*. What had hit him? A spell? Who shot it—

Black eyes. White pupils. A distant face. Reynold's blood ran cold. He saw a Goblin standing in the distance, raising his hand as black magic swirled around him. The [Butler] shouted.

“[Invisibility Field]!”

The carriage vanished. Goblins snarled as they jumped for where he should be, loosing arrows, trying to slow the coach's momentum with their bodies. Reynold spun away as more black bolts of magic flashed by his head. A Goblin clung to the carriage door—he cut it off. One stabbed him

from behind and he threw it off as he fought with the reins. Where were the villagers? Gone?

Reynold burst out of the group of Goblins as more arrows shot after him. He reached for the potion that he kept in the compartment under the carriage. His world was growing dark. He found the bottle, and looked back.

The villagers hadn't made it to the hills yet. They were nearly there, but the Goblins were reforming, coming after them. Quick! Reynold gritted his teeth. One last time. He turned the coach.

Blood was sticking to its sides, making it visible despite the spell. Reynold drove it onwards. He saw the Goblin with black eyes raising his hand, felt the black bolts of energy make the carriage shudder and groan. He drove into the Goblins. A duty.

He had a duty—

An arrow slammed him back in his seat. Reynold turned and saw a Hob leaping towards him. He raised his sword—

A duty.

The sun was low in the sky, as a traveler in a red cloak stood by the gates to Celum and waited impatiently. He had waited *all day*, and it was practically night time already. He was considering leaving—in fact, he'd tried to several times, but something drew him back.

The first was the knowledge that this meeting had been arranged, and that Magnolia Reinhart was not one to break her word. The second was that he knew that it was a meeting worth pursuing. Still, the lack of any vehicles

on the horizon had left him worried, and so he was debating stepping inside the city limits for food or a drink and sending another [Message] spell when he saw it.

On the horizon, a shape. Something moving incredibly fast down the road, headed towards him. The traveler stepped forwards in relief as he heard [Guardsmen] call out a warning on the battlements above. But that relief turned to alarm as he saw the carriage approaching in more detail.

It was pink, or it had been. But red splatters of blood had dried on the front. The carriage was damaged in multiple places, and the driver—

“Dead gods.”

As the guards on Celum’s walls shouted the alarm, the traveler saw the carriage heading straight towards him. It turned and drifted for a moment before stopping in a shower of mud and snow which barely missed the traveler. The driver paused and leaned forwards over his reins as the ghostly horses stood in the cold. He was covered in blood and an arrow was sticking out of his leg. He turned his head towards the traveler, and smiled weakly.

“I presume you are my guest for this trip? I do apologize for the delay.”

“Ancestors, are you alright?”

“Never better.”

Reynold pulled the arrow from his thigh and splashed a healing potion onto the wound with shaking hands. He glanced at the traveler as he pulled back his hood and froze.

“*You?* That is to say, er—I am delighted to be driving such an esteemed personage, uh, sir—”

“You’re sure you’re alright? You look like you’ve been through a war!”

The traveler seemed more concerned with his health. Reynold straightened.

“Not to worry, sir! I merely had a run in with a few thousand Goblins. I assure you, I will be taking an alternate route on the return trip. If you will step into the carriage?”

“You’re sure you don’t need a [Healer] or another healing potion? What *happened* to you?”

Professionalism. Reynold gave the man his best smile as he sipped from the healing potion.

“Goblins, sir. Nothing to worry about. There is a cheese platter in an overhead compartment, I believe. Please help yourself and accept my deepest apologies for any mess that may have occurred. I would also like to render my sincerest regrets for the delay, which was caused by errors of my colleagues. And for the blood.”

He stared down at the traveler as guardsmen on the walls and gates shouted at him. The traveler hesitated. He looked around and realized that there were only moments before they were surrounded by Humans. He looked up at Reynold.

“Tell me, young...man. Are all of Magnolia Reinhart’s servants like you?”

Reynold grinned a bit manically at the traveler. He laughed, which was a serious breach of etiquette, but given the circumstances, understandable and worth it.

“Only the best of us, sir. Only the best. Shall we go?”

“I suppose. Yes, I suppose there’s no backing out of it now, is there?”

The traveler hesitated at the doors, but eventually stepped in. Reynold heard the carriage doors shut, and turned the carriage. Guardsmen shouted at him, trying to get him to stop. Reynold brushed hands away and flicked the reins. The carriage shot into motion, leaving the shouting people behind.

“I regret to say that our journey may be delayed by an hour or two, sir. Damage to the carriage has reduced our speed, and I must drive out of the way of the Goblin Lord’s army.”

“You mean you’ve seen them?”

“I believe parts of them are still stuck to the undercarriage, sir. May I take this moment to inform you of our wine selection?”

There was no response. Reynold laughed to himself. He was—was a bit disoriented himself. As he sped away from Celum he saw little black spots swimming in his vision, and felt his body swaying. He was...tired.

But he kept driving. He was a [Butler]. And a butler never abandoned his post. He owed Magnolia Reinhart too much for that.

Slowly, one of the wounds that hadn’t completely healed opened up again and spattered blood onto the front of the carriage, mixing with the rest. After a while, Reynold sipped more of the healing potion and the wound closed.

“Dear me. My attire is ruined. I should get that cleaned...as soon as I stop to rest.”

He sighed, and kept his eyes on the road. The last of the daylight burned away, and Reynold felt his body freezing. He was cold. It was dark. He reached for more energy, more fire, and felt himself drifting lower. But that was just his body. At the moment Reynold was full of life. He’d rest when it was over. For now he drove.

And inside the carriage, the traveler watched the driver through the panel. He stared anxiously at the man, but saw Reynold driving without faltering. And perhaps it was the unfamiliar sensation of riding in the carriage, or the instinctual understanding that Reynold wouldn't stop until he'd completed his duty, but the traveler soon felt himself growing tired.

He slept. And then he dreamed.

It was the past the traveler dreamed of. It was a memory that surfaced in his mind, an old conversation between him and a friend. It was ancient history, decades old, but it came to mind because of what he was about to do. He recalled a tent, the smell of wine, a slightly rough chair, and—company. He sat down, not remembering what the joke he'd just laughed at was, and saw his friend sitting across from him.

His friend. A long-dead face swam into focus in the traveler's dream, and a voice spoke.

"I think I met a monster today."

"Oh, really? What kind?"

"Hah. Not a real monster. I was speaking metaphorically. I met a Human girl. A young one. You might know of her. Magnolia Reinhart."

"I don't know the first name, but I recognize the last one. Well, well. One of the scions of the Five Families has come to our aid?"

"It seems like it. She's responsible for that army. And this is the scary part—I'd swear she's not even seventeen years of age. Maybe less; I don't know Humans that well."

“What, all of that army? Is she some kind of [Commander]?”

“Hardly. She’s a [Lady]. And she’s certainly no warrior—I caught her throwing up after battle.”

“Why’s she come, then?”

“Because no one else would come to our aid otherwise. She came herself and brought an army capable of ending this war with her.”

“I’ll drink to her, then. Why’d you say you met a monster? Surely she’s not *that* hideous—”

“Don’t be a hatchling. I was being serious. I thought she was a monster when I met her. Now...I’m convinced.”

“You’ve lost me.”

“Let me say it another way. She’s a...Demon. You know, the ones from Rhir? Or maybe she’s something else. What I’m saying is that she scares me. She’s not like other Humans.”

“So? She must be outstanding to lead an army so young. She’s high level...so what? I’m not following you.”

“Hm. Perhaps I could say it like this. She’s like...a god.”

“The gods are dead.”

“Yes, but you know what I mean, don’t you? She’s like a god, or the opposite of one. Does that make sense?”

“Perhaps...she frightens you and she’s that different from her kind, is she?”

“Yes. Perhaps that’s the easiest way of saying it. It was the look in her eyes. I won’t forget it. She was throwing up when I saw her, but when she

finished and turned—she was the one who rallied the Humans. All by herself, I’m sure of it. And they followed her. A coalition army of Humans to rescue us, the Drakes. Do you understand?”

“I think I do. But surely that’s not—”

“Just listen. I had a chance to talk with her. Just a short moment—you know how politics are. But it was when we had a chance that she really frightened me. I asked her what had prompted her to come to our aid when our species have been enemies for so long. And you know what she said?”

“What?”

“Just guess.”

“You know I’m no good at guessing. Tell me.”

“It was the same thing they said long ago. The same thing that the Five Families, the original Five Families said that they wanted as they were invading us, driving us back the first time. The same word, and I’ll wager, the same look of conviction.”

“I don’t know that word. So you’re saying she’s some kind of leader? A dangerous one for the future?”

“I don’t know. All I know is that I’m as wary of her as I am of the Antinium. That look in her eye, the way she speaks—it’s not that she’s not charismatic or a natural leader. Other people are—you and I lead. But it was the look, you see? The look and the conviction. She believes wholeheartedly in what she’s doing, and that’s what scares me.”

“Just tell me the damned word already, will you? What does she want?”

“Peace.”

“Peace?”

Zel Shivertail paused as he sipped from his cup and raised his head incredulously.

“That’s what I said.”

The Drake sitting across from him nodded. General Sserys, hero of the First Antinium War, smiled crookedly.

“A little girl leading an army to fight the Antinium. For peace. To save the world, she said. And you know what? She looked like a child then, with vomit dripping off her chin, but when I asked if it was possible, she just smiled. And then she looked like...I don’t know. Not a [Queen] or a [Lady], but something more. Like the opposite of a god, if they were alive. She stuck out her hand and said that I should join her. Together we could end the war and save the world.”

“And what, did you take it?”

Zel waited. Sserys shook his head.

“I didn’t get the chance. We were interrupted by some other Humans—[Lords], you know. But it stuck with me. Her offer. I felt like she was sucking me in, that she could see something I didn’t. I was afraid, Shivertail, and I won’t ever admit that to anyone else. I was afraid of her peace, of what she saw.”

“Afraid of a little Human girl. General Sserys, [Spear of the Drakes]. Afraid of peace.”

“That’s right.”

General Sserys looked at him, and Zel Shivertail paused for a second before bursting out laughing. The other Drake grinned in acknowledgement of the joke, and then he filled Zel’s cup. The two Drakes raised their cups in a silent toast and Zel raised it to his lips—

“*Reynold?* My goodness. Ressa! Get him healing potions and help him off of the carriage, quickly!”

A voice woke Zel Shivertail from his slumbers. He jerked awake in the carriage and realized he’d stopped. And then he realized who was speaking and froze. He sensed people rushing towards the carriage, and heard a sharp voice.

“Was it [Assassins]? How badly are you injured? Is the guest safe?”

“No attack—just Goblins. I do apologize, Lady Reinhart—I made a decision to protect a group of travelers—I have also bloodied my uniform, Ressa, for which I apologize.”

“Never mind that. Ressa, get the man inside. He’s *frozen*! Why is he so cold? Are the heating spells on the carriage broken again? And what about —”

The voice stopped as Zel opened the carriage door. The Drake [General] stared out into a dark world illuminated by bright mage lights and blinked down at the figures clustered around the [Butler] who was being held up by two servants. They were all Humans—well, all save for one of the [Maids] who was a Gnoll. And they stared at him with a mixture of awe and fear.

They knew him as a legend. One of the [Maids], a tall woman, moved slowly backwards towards a shorter woman, keeping her eyes on him. It was too dark for Zel to make out details, but the way she held herself, and her voice—he had never met her, and she had never met him.

But they knew each other. Zel Shivertail lowered his head slightly as he stepped from the carriage. Magnolia Reinhart moved past Ressa’s protective body and smiled.

“General Shivertail. I’m glad you decided to come. My apologies for the delay.”

Zel paused and nodded to Reynold. The [Butler] was still on his feet, being fussed over by two [Maids].

“Your man looked like he’d driven through a war and back to get to me. I commend his spirit.”

“Happy to serve.”

Reynold mumbled. Magnolia glanced at him, and then at Zel. Cautiously, slowly, she held out her hand.

“We have never met, but I hope we can speak freely, Zel Shivertail. I have long wanted to meet you, as you are no doubt aware. I hope we can set the issues you put forward in your letter right.”

“I have no doubt we can. But I have one question to ask you first. Something I have to know.”

Zel didn’t take Magnolia’s offered hand. He looked her in the eye and sensed Ressa staring at him warily, felt the prickles on his spines that told him the other servants were dangerous. But it was only Magnolia’s face he searched.

“Tell me why.”

“Why...what, precisely?”

“Why you’ve gone to all this trouble. Why you’re willing to help. Why all the things you promised me. What’s in it for you?”

Magnolia lowered her hand and tapped her lips.

“Nothing, perhaps. But it is my mission, shall we say? My ambition, most definitely. I have one dream, General Shivertail.”

“Which is?”

Zel held his breath. The world did. Magnolia Reinhart smiled, and in her eyes was a bright light. She held out her hand once more.

“Peace. To save the world. I will do anything for that goal. Will you help me?”

Zel Shivertail looked into her eyes. For a second he saw what Sserys had, decades ago. That light, that certainty. The other Drake had called it the look of a devil, a monster, or a god. And then he blinked, and saw something different. He hesitated, and then his claw rose. Gingerly, somewhere in the past of what might have been, the Drake [General] shook the Human girl’s hands.

And then they were back in the present, in the now. Zel looked into Magnolia’s eyes and smiled.

“Let’s save the world then, Miss Reinhart. Tell me, where should we begin?”

She laughed lightly, in relief, as Ressa let out a huge breath behind her and Reynold fainted.

“With the Goblins, my dear Zel. With the Goblin Lord first. And then Az’kerash. And then the Antinium.”

“And then?”

She smiled wider.

“We’ll see. Now, shall we discuss this inside? Say, over a cup of tea?”

4.39 G

“Fools!”

The instant Garen Redfang heard about the failed attack on Lady Rie’s mansion, he stormed into the feasting hall where Tremborag sat. The self-styled Great Chieftain of Goblins looked up as he clutched an entire roast sheep in his claws. Garen snarled as he strode down the length of the messy hall towards him.

“Garen Redfang. What has you so angry this time?”

Tremborag’s voice was huge and surprisingly intellectual, but tinged with the same irritation Garen had been feeling lately. The few Hobs and other Goblins accompanying him at this moment—many of them female—eyed the Goblins behind Garen.

The Redfang Tribe had largely abandoned Garen when Rags had fled the mountain. But many was not all, and already more Hobs and competent warriors had joined Garen Redfang’s faction within the mountain. He was the pinnacle of martial ability to aspire to, and if his new ‘tribe’ was not as well-trained as his old one, they were a fighting force Garen had led on many raids.

And it was the raids that were the issue. Garen glared at Tremborag and spat.

“The Goblins who went to attack the [Lady] are dead.”

The huge Hobgoblin paused. A bit of grease dripped from his hands. The Goblins around him froze.

“All?”

Over twenty Hobs had been chosen to assault the mansion, as well as one of the [Shamans]. It had been considered overkill for such a small town and even a [Lady]'s personal residence. Unlike the Five Families, most of the minor nobility lacked huge arsenals of magical defenses.

And yet, the attackers had been destroyed. Garen spoke sharply.

“They were slaughtered by a Human alliance! They are gathering as I said! And you provoke them with more raids. No more. No Goblins will go to that place; none return anymore. I forbid it.”

His command of the common tongue had increased markedly since he had stayed in the mountain. Or rather, he was having to speak more often. As he had in the past with his friends. Garen pushed the memory back. Tremborag dropped the sheep and stood.

“*You* forbid? I am Great Chieftain under the mountain.”

“And I am Garen Redfang, who knows raiding and Humans ways. Continue to send more raids and they will die. Fool.”

The hall had gone silent. The Goblins around Tremborag had retreated and Garen's Redfang warriors were eying Tremborag uneasily. The Great Chieftain's crimson eyes flared with fury. He and Garen growled at each other, drawing closer.

The air was hot with bloodlust. Garen felt his hand tightening on the hilt of his famous red sword and Tremborag suddenly looked taller, less fat and more like the monster he could become. But both Goblins forced themselves back. They were allies.

“Hah! You have not dulled your fangs since coming here.”

Tremborag broke the stalemate first. He sat and picked up the sheep and ripped into it with one hand. Breathing hard, Garen sat at a table, facing him.

There was a reason for the irritation between them, and not just because of Rags' escape. What had she taken? Some of the magical items? Most of the truly powerful artifacts had been spread across the Hob lieutenants and other warriors in Tremborag's tribe. Goblins didn't hoard practical treasures. And food? Again, not an issue. The Human women—

No. Garen ground his teeth together. There was only one true reason for their anger.

"The Goblin Lord comes."

"Yes."

Tremborag ate savagely, crunching bones in his mouth. He spat a fragment onto the ground.

"I feel him coming. He comes for you and I, Redfang. We are the only ones who could oppose him. But there are others he calls."

"Others?"

Garen was surprised. Tremborag laughed.

"You think you are the only famous Chieftain, Redfang? Far to the north there are other tribes who make Humans tremble, just as there are ones to the south and on other continents. Two I think of. A pyromaniac witch and a brute who loves combat."

"Would they join us? Or would they join the Goblin Lord?"

Again the Great Chieftain laughed.

"I have asked, and they have refused me. They would refuse him too, I think. The witch, she refused the Goblin *King* as I did. As for the brute, he accepts no one as his master. No, they will wait, I think. The Goblin Lord comes for only us."

“Unless the Humans come first. You provoke them.”

The Hob crossed his arms. Tremborag nodded.

“They have forgotten why they fear us. Let them come to the mountain. We will break them in the tunnels, lure them in and crush them. And in their fury, they will hunt that wretch, that *thief*, the Goblin who takes a Human name!”

Rags. Angry as he was, Tremborag still refused to speak her name. Garen stared at him and turned.

“And when the Goblin Lord comes? Then what? Will you sit and eat until he comes to your doorstep with a host far vaster than yours?”

“Let him. I am the Great Chieftain of the mountain. I will bow to no Lord, no King. And one last thing.”

Tremborag’s voice boomed as Garen strode out of the hall. The Hob turned. Now Tremborag was serious.

“Go to the mansion and destroy it, Redfang. If the [Lady] remains, slaughter her people and bring her back to the mountain.”

Garen stared at him. Vengeance, retribution. An eye for an eye. Tremborag was very Human in that regard.

“And if they are not there? If they are under the protection of the one who builds those wooden markers, who calls himself an [Emperor]?”

The whispers had reached the Goblin ears as they skulked around the edges of that strange land. Tremborag grinned and his eyes were fury.

“In that case, we will destroy every village, town, and city in that place until all is gore and ash. After the Goblin Lord or perhaps—before? Go.”

For the moment he was Garen's Chieftain, so Garen went. He took a massive force of Hobs and Goblins to the home of the Valerund House and found the mansion deserted. He burned the mansion and determined that there was no point riding after the lady.

Garen had Skills from the [Raider] class that allowed him to appraise targets. And so he destroyed a town many miles to the north instead, robbing it of many lumps of gold recently acquired from a mine. And as he rode back to the mountain Garen wondered what Rags was doing. The Humans would not suffer the Goblins much longer.

Already, they had begun to counterattack.

The Goblins in the Flooded Waters tribe weren't restless. At least, most of them weren't. They raided roads on a daily basis and clashed with monsters and small bands of Humans regularly. Moreover, they were secure in their semi-permanent home in the forest of tall trees around the lake. Already, the Goblins were beginning to think of it as their base. But more importantly, they were filling their bellies from their raids and they were not in danger, not in want. They were content.

But the Goblins who thought of the future, those who were leaders like Noears, Poisonbite, Redscar, the Rockfall Chieftain, and other Hobs of Tremborag's mountain, thought otherwise. They could tell what their Chieftain wished because they were connected. They were part of the same tribe. And what those Goblins understood was that Rags was...aimless.

"She does not know what to do."

Poisonbite declared this as she sat with her unit of female Goblins around a fire. She had a few guests. Two Hobs from Tremborag's faction,

Noears, the Rockfall Chieftain, and Redscar. They were just guests. But that they were here, listening, was significant.

Each one had their own agendas. Noears, who was very intelligent and dangerous because of it, played with a spark of electricity, letting it crawl over his hands. The other Goblins looked around surreptitiously.

They were looking for Rags. Or Pyrite. The Goldstone Chieftain was staunchly loyal to her, which might be troublesome if he heard anything. Not that they were doing anything; they were just talking. But in Tremborag's mountain, talk was dangerous enough.

Here it was...a sign of wariness. Noears flicked the spark into the fire, making it jump, and looked up.

"She is aimless, but not, I think, lost."

The others nodded at that. Noears continued.

"She does not know whether to stay or go. This is a good place. But not what she wants. She wants to go south. But the Goblin Lord is there."

"Dangerous."

Redscar grunted. He wasn't talkative. He flicked a dagger up and caught the blade between two fingers.

"Should go."

He wanted to return to the High Passes. Noears scratched at the ragged holes where his ears had been and shrugged.

"Perhaps. But she is—"

He broke off as a Goblin that was known to be too talkative for his own good passed by the fire. The other Goblins stared blankly at him and looked around the camp. No Rags. She was snoozing by her fire. And Pyrite? Sitting under one of the gargantuan trees by the lakeside.

Safe. Noears stuck a finger in his earhole and came out with some sticky earwax as he went on.

“Chieftain wants to go back. Goblin Lord is dangerous. So she waits. Not lost, but waiting. For right chance. Smart. I agree, which is why I follow her.”

The Rockfall Chieftain nodded at once. She was a supporter of Rags, which is why her listening here was good. All opinions mattered. But Poisonbite was restless. She was no Hob, but it was the opinion of those around the fire that she had the same rank as one. Just like Noears was the strongest [Mage] in the tribe by far—being small didn’t mean weak. Rags was an example of that.

“Still should do more. Build base here. Raid harder.”

She disliked only robbing travelers on the road, especially since they were growing fewer as of late. Redscar nodded his approval as did two of the Hobs. Noears frowned and looked around.

Rags? No sign of her. Pyrite was on his feet, breaking up a fight between a few Goblins. He grunted, but it was another Hob who spoke.

“Chieftain. Needs fight. Goblin Lord.”

A simple sentence, but one with nuance, as his jiggling leg indicated. The idea of fighting a Goblin Lord was, of course, *wrong*, but if he was like what Garen Redfang had claimed, what other choice was there? He used dead Goblins, raised the dead. And he slaughtered Goblins who did not obey him.

“Should talk first.”

Noears was the first to dissent. Redscar glared, and the argument descended into infighting. It was just talk. They kept glancing over towards

Rags, just to reassure themselves she was asleep. And now Pyrite was tending to a fire, sniffing hopefully at a stick of mushrooms roasting by it.

“Chieftain is young.”

“Yes. Needs help.”

Scoffing from other Goblins.

“Help? Like Garen Redfang? Another Chieftain? Two?”

Hand wave, claw clenched into fist. Subtlety, of course, not the first interpretation, but a more nuanced answer.

“Not Redfang. But advisor. Someone strong.”

“She is not strong?”

“Not *strong*.”

All heads turned. Rags didn’t appear to stab them. Pyrite was lifting a Goblin child up, grunting as he peered at a rash. All turned back to the talk.

“Smart, though.”

“Yes.”

Waggled finger. More nuance. Smart is not enough necessarily. Goblins need a daring leader and a cautious one is not as good. However, the raised eyebrow indicated skepticism of this very idea. The Rockfall Chieftain surprisingly spoke up next.

“Good to have mate.”

All stared at her. There, it was said, and by one of Rags’ own at that! Mate. Yes. Have sex. Or rather, have someone who could guide your opinions, a capable lieutenant. Only—

“Pyrite is good.”

Poisonbite said that and all agreed. Pyrite was. He was capable, solid, a good fighter. And he was calm, a perfect second-in-command. What he *wasn't*, though, was aggressive. Noears chewed on his lip and frowned.

“Good, but simple. Has odd companion. Old. Greybeard.”

That was true too. Every head turned as Pyrite bent to talk to a Goblin sitting by a fire next to theirs. Greybeard grinned as he slurped at some soup and chattered to the big Hob. Poisonbite scowled and Redscar looked at her.

“Old Goblin. You know?”

“My unit. Good at running away, better at not be cut.”

She flicked her fingers dismissively and Redscar nodded.

“Never met Goblin with beard.”

“Hah! No point. But if not Pyrite, who?”

Who indeed. All eyes shifted to Noears and Redscar, the most probable choices. Noears shifted and Redscar growled. Neither one was particularly into the idea. It was common knowledge that Noears liked big Hob females, and Redscar liked Goblins who had certain body parts that Rags lacked. Added to that, no one wanted to imagine Rags being swayed by one side more than the other.

And yet—aimlessness. The other Goblins hesitated. Noears grimaced.

“Chieftain must do *something*.”

“Why?”

Poisonbite rolled her eyes as someone asked that. Her voice was laced with open scorn.

“Because aimlessness is bad, *stupid*.”

“Really?”

She growled.

“Yes! Why we talking if not?”

She turned angrily to the speaker and her green face went white. Pyrite stood over the fire, crunching on a giant Barkeater Beetle. He waved at the group calmly.

Where had he come from? The other Goblins stared in shock. Pyrite had appeared without them really paying attention from across the camp. He’d snuck up on them like—like a mountain, always in plain sight, but never really noticed. He sat and all the Goblins edged away from him. All save for Redscar, who just looked wary.

“Chieftain is aimless.”

Pyrite’s voice hushed the other Goblins. He nodded and offered the giant beetle with huge mandibles around. No one wanted a bite. He went back to crunching as the beetle’s guts oozed out the back.

“Aimless. Young. No sex. Not Hob. Not warrior. Not going to war and not building base.”

He paused, having summarized the complaints of the others. They waited. Pyrite fished a wiggling leg out from between his teeth and crunched at it for a second.

“So what?”

Every eye was on him. Pyrite shook his head. A voice cackled—they realized Greybeard had appeared at their fire. The elderly Hob was sipping from his bowl and glancing at Pyrite. The former Goldstone Chieftain nodded.

“So what? Young is young. Aimless is temporary. Chieftain is Chieftain. Will grow.”

“So he says!”

Greybeard laughed into the thoughtful silence Pyrite’s words had caused. He clapped Pyrite on the back and the Hob grunted. The old Hob sighed.

“Wait and see? Is good plan if nothing coming!”

“But is?”

Poisonbite had been alarmed at Pyrite being here, but the Hob was clearly as affable as ever despite the...talk. Greybeard on the other hand was a nuisance. She wouldn’t have suffered him if Pyrite clearly didn’t favor him. Come to that, he was always hanging around the old Hob. Poisonbite didn’t see the point. But then, Greybeard only really talked to Pyrite.

Noears wondered what he said as he stared at the Hob. Greybeard looked up, beard soaked with soup, and his eyes flashed.

“Something is coming. Can’t you feel it, younglings?”

The other Goblins stared at him, surprised by the sudden change in his tone. Pyrite stopped crunching his beetle and looked up. Then all the Goblins in the camp heard the horn call in the distance. Rags shot out of the hammock she’d built by her fire and one of the Goblin lookouts perched in the trees shouted. Something was coming.

Humans.

“My, but they are upset, aren’t they? Look at them looking around like ants. Or is that because we’re on a hilltop?”

Lady Bethal Walchaís stood on the hilltop and stared down at the Flooded Waters tribe as the Goblins shot to their feet and began reaching for weapons. By her side Sir Thomast the Chevalier, her husband, said nothing. Neither did the ranks of [Knights] dressed from head to toe in red-pink armor. They were her personal order of warriors, known appropriately as the Knights of the Petal or, as she sometimes called them, her Rose Knights.

And they were here to kill the Goblins. However, one of the oddities of the scene and probably the reason why the Goblin Chieftain hadn’t ordered the attack was the disparity in numbers. There were several *thousand* Goblins below. Probably six thousand. Eight? Not all were combatants obviously, but they were enough to become a sea of green. Whereas Lady Bethal had brought half of the [Knights] under her command and left half to guard her fiefdom.

That meant just over forty Rose Knights were arrayed in a line on the hilltop. And yet, Lady Bethal looked unconcerned. Dressed in elegant riding clothes and mounted on a stallion as she was, she might have been out for a ride with her retainers. She peered down towards the Goblin camp and pointed.

“There. That is their Chieftain.”

A small Goblin riding a Carn Wolf and carrying an outsized black crossbow was her target. Bethal clapped her hands and her Rose Knights stood straighter.

“Kill the Chieftain, and destroy as many Hobs and high-level Goblins on your way to her as possible, please. I will allow six to guard me, including you, Thomast.”

He looked at her. Bethal's tone softened for a second.

"Oh, don't look at me like that. We spoke about this! Or rather, I did. You know it has to be done."

He stared at her in silence. Bethal's tone sharpened. Her fingers dug into his arm. Thomast wore no armor; the silk doublet he wore would have fit just as well at the party where he and Bethal had met with Lady Magnolia a few weeks ago. Neither did he flinch as Bethal's long nails dug into his arm.

For a second the air around Bethal was thorny, and then she was letting go, withdrawing her nails, clearly upset. She brushed at his arm and drew herself closer to the taller man. She spoke softly.

"They are raiders and they slaughtered those villagers, Thomast."

The Chevalier said nothing, but his silence spoke louder than Bethal's words. She shifted.

"Yes, they killed off a Goblin tribe. What of it? Magnolia has asked me personally to settle this, and so I shall. These Goblins cannot be allowed to continue disrupting trade, and if they joined up with the Goblin Lord—ah, honor's end, Thomast! Do you see them using pikes and crossbows? What if all the Goblins fought so? They must end here and now."

She glared again. He was silent as the wind ruffled his hair. Bethal's anger collapsed.

"I know! But—oh, Thomast."

The Goblins had begun forming up into ranks, and the front rank was holding terribly long pikes, while a group of mounted Goblins on wolf-back circled through the forest. They were approaching as a single mass, and yet no one interrupted Bethal's soliloquy. Or was it a monologue? It was hard to call it a dialogue.

“What must be, must be, my love. Do not begrudge me for ordering you this.”

Thomast bent his head and Bethal wept as she clung to him.

“It must be! I—a small wrong, an evil to make the world better for some. So Magnolia says and so I believe. But do you? Will you fight for me, my love, even if I am wrong? Even if the world would judge me so? Would you abandon honor for me? And would you love me after, my heart?”

His arm encircled her body. Thomast bent and whispered a word.

“Always.”

The two stood thusly for a second, and then turned. The Goblins were streaming out of the forest, lining up in formations. Already some were taking ranging shots with their crossbows or slings, but the small Goblin mounted on a Carn Wolf was ordering them to hold their fire. Bethal sighed.

“Let us begin, then. My Rose Knights—advance!”

And they did. The Rose Knights of Walchaís charged down the hill with a roar, crashing into the ranks of the disbelieving Goblins.

Rags had been having a bad day. Indigestion had plagued her from the Barkeater Beetles that Pyrite had convinced her to try, and she was certain someone was talking behind her back. More than that though, she’d felt horribly aimless and out of sorts, feeling the Goblin Lord’s approach and not knowing what she should do. All her certainty about how she would ride out and confront him had melted away.

So she'd been pleasantly surprised by the news of the [Lady] and her small escort. Robbing a rich noble blind and finding out what her magical artifacts did would be a pleasant diversion. So why—why—

Why were they *losing*?

The thirty or so armored Humans ran straight into the ranks of the twenty-foot-long pikes that Rags had drilled her Goblins with. They could stop a charging group of cavalry and had done so more than once. It was suicide for anyone to run into that wall of spikes. Or it should have been.

The first Rose Knight was struck by two pikes in the chest and shoulder. The Goblins hadn't been content to wait for him to come to them; Rags had ordered the charge and they'd rammed into him at high-speed. Impaling speed.

But the tips of both pikes just glanced off his armor. Another one caught him in the midriff and Rags saw something improbable happen. Instead of the armor deforming under the pressure of the blow, the shock of impact travelled down the sturdy pike and made the eight Goblins running with it slam into each other.

The pike had struck the Human in armor head-on and his armor had been the victor. The Rose Knight ran past the pike, the axe in his hands raised. He charged into a Hob and took a heavy mace hit to the head. He ignored it and cut the Hob down with one tremendous blow. Across the line of pikes and infantry, the same was happening. That was when Rags knew she was in trouble.

Enchanted armor! She waved her hands desperately and shouted. Goblins who had been assigned to watch her in the middle of battles picked up on what she wanted and the scrum of infantry around the Rose Knights drew back. They left eighteen Hobs dead and over fifty more Goblins when they did.

So many casualties. Rags' eyes burned as she raised a fist and clenched it. The Rose Knights looked up as Goblins wielding crossbows—hundreds of them sitting in trees or lined up in formations—loosed as one.

Steel and wood-tipped bolts struck the armored knights from every side in a huge semicircle the Goblins had formed so as not to hit one another. For a second, the air was filled with so many projectiles that Rags could see nothing amid the splintering bolts and—

The Rose Knights strode out of the hail of arrows, unscathed. Their armor gleamed pink and red with blood. The Goblins stared. Rags' eyes slowly travelled up to the woman standing with an escort of six knights around her. She could have sworn the [Lady] was smiling at her.

Unacceptable. Rags' eyes flashed. She raised her voice and shouted as the Rose Knights charged once again.

“Mages! Hobs!”

Pyrite heard the call and knew it was a bad one. It was the only one Rags could make, but it was still a bad one. He shifted as the rank of Hobs around him surged forwards. Pyrite charged forwards and saw a press of huge bodies in front of him, fighting the strange pink knights. But already, Hobs were falling.

Their enemy was too strong.

Magical weapons cleaved through the air, splitting steel shields, emitting jets of fire or, in one case, leaving sharp after-trails of light in the air that cut whatever they touched. The Rose Knights were unstoppable. Because of their armor.

It was too strong! And though Rags had had a good idea, the thinking part of Pyrite, the calm part that analyzed everything, told him that if an enemy had come here, they would have taken measures against mere strength or spells. Sure enough, the Hobs failed to damage the armor even when they swung with their full strength. And the lightning coming from Noears and the other [Mages] glanced off the armor harmlessly as well when it should have shocked the wearers to death.

Impressive magic. Was it not metal they were wearing? Pyrite's eyes narrowed as he came face-to-face with one of the Rose Knights in the scrum of bodies. He swung and the Rose Knight raised his shield as he countered with a thrust of his sword.

Bad trade. Pyrite halted his swing and backed up. The thrust missed him, leaving a trail of freezing cold in the air behind it. The [Knight] paused, and then swung again, raising his or her shield.

Nope. Pyrite knew they were waiting for him to strike so they could exchange blows. It didn't matter if *they* got hit. He knocked aside the blade with his axe's head, feeling the chill on his hands. Enchanted blades, enchanted armor—

“Withdraw!”

The roar was going up from the Hobs around him and they were scrambling to get back as the Rose Knights cut them down. Pyrite was glad to hear it. Rags was no fool. She'd realized the Hobs would only be slaughtered and now she was bringing in—

Pyrite glanced over his shoulder as the [Knight] thrust at him again. Casually, Pyrite knocked the blade away again; it was easy if you kept backing up. Goblins were drawing back, inviting the Knights into one-versus-hundreds battles in every direction. And the pink knights were taking the offer.

That was bad. Pyrite walked backwards quickly, letting the knight charge towards him. Other Goblins were jabbing at the pink knight from all angles, but he—or she—had clearly decided Pyrite was dying first. The knight ignored the attacks on their armor, beheading a Goblin with a cut to one side.

Pyrite's eyes narrowed. He slid to one side as the knight lunged and brought his axe down like a hammer on their back.

[Power Strike]! Pyrite hadn't learned a more advanced Skill, but he had once cleaved through a warhorse's armor and spine with this blow—

His axe *shattered* as he struck the Rose Knight. The armored warrior stumbled mid-step and then turned towards Pyrite. The Hob and the Goblins around him stared at the Rose Knight and then backed up. This wasn't fair at all.

A group of Goblins with pikes charged into the pink knight, holding them off for a few moments. Pyrite backed up again, and saw the battle was going the same way throughout the forest. The Rose Knights were carving their way through the Goblins trying to damage their armor with impunity. It was carnage, and Pyrite felt the fury in his heart rising as he saw his people dying.

Yet the cold part of him still approved. This made sense. How did you destroy an enemy most efficiently? You sent in warriors—you didn't have to have many—to fight. Warriors the enemy could *not* harm in any way.

Because of levels. Because they didn't have enough enchanted weapons or Skills. Or if they did—Pyrite saw one of the Rose Knights raise his shield and it was like a wall the Goblins couldn't break through. Another was cutting with his battleaxe as if it were as light as a feather, and one more had used a Skill that had sent a group of Goblins flying.

They were high-level too. And so Pyrite realized what Rags would do next. What she had to do.

Retreat.

But where could they go? The Rose Knights would harry them, cut them down or aim for her. A group was already cutting towards Rags. And she was pointing—at the [Lady]?

“Ah.”

Pyrite realized what she was doing. Harm the leader if you can’t hurt the soldiers. A rain of crossbow bolts fell like rain from the sky at the unarmored woman. She in turn raised a hand and—

“[Tranquil Skies].”

The bolts and arrows parted in the sky—as did the clouds, in fact. Pyrite, Rags, and the Goblins who had time to look stared as the [Lady] smiled. The bolts rained down around her and her escort, in a huge circle of—of tranquility around her. The clouded sky was blue above her head.

That wasn’t *fair*. It was ingenious, but not fair. Rags was practically screaming as she ordered a second volley. The [Lady] couldn’t do that twice!

She didn’t have to. As the crossbows raised a second time, one of the Rose Knights *roared*. For a second he towered over the Goblins, his armor twisting, the gaps in his visor shining with terrible light. He was a monster—every bow and crossbow turned towards him and loosed at once.

The knight took the hail of death without flinching. Pyrite rubbed his eyes and the illusion was gone. But another Knight had begun hammering on their shield, using another Skill which created a target for the Goblins to hit.

They were dominating the battlefield with their Skills. And as a group of Hobs and Redfang warriors charged into the escort around the lady, Pyrite saw the only other unarmored man on the battlefield step forwards.

He was a [Fencer] if the rapier was anything to mark him by. And he was *good*. The man stabbed five Redfang warriors through their guards as they charged him at once, and the six pink knights cut down the other Goblins without budging from their place surrounding the [Lady]. She wrinkled her nose as blood fountained into the air.

Death. Pyrite felt it in the air. He looked around—Rags was sitting on her mount, looking stunned. The Carn Wolves and Redfang warriors, her elite, were dueling the Rose Knights now and still, the knights took no damage. They were invincible.

The Goblins had to retreat. Pyrite grunted as the knight who'd been pursuing him broke past the pikes and began cutting towards him. He glanced over his shoulder. Only water behind. The lake would cut their retreat off. Rags would have to run them through the forest, but what if there was a second force waiting? Or what if they had ways to catch up with them? The lake's waters were turning red as blood ran into them—

Water. Lake. Pyrite blinked and turned as the freezing longsword swept towards his head again. He backed up, then turned and ran.

The knight followed. Pyrite splashed past ranks of Goblins in the water. They'd already been pushed this far? He turned and raised the haft of his broken axe as he stood in stomach-deep water. Predictably, the knight had followed him. Their blade was freezing the water around them as they waded towards Pyrite. That was interesting.

And they were clearly not thinking straight. If they had been, they would have realized that the water slowed both Hob and knight. Yet the

sword came swinging at Pyrite all the same, and he had to admit—it was dangerous.

Pyrite ducked. The knight cut into the water and was rewarded with an impact at last. Blood spurted up in the water, but the blow hadn't been decisive, slowed as it had been by the liquid. The knight raised their sword for a final strike—

And Pyrite fountained up out of the water. He body-slammed the knight and they crashed into the lake together, underwater. He felt the knight flailing, sensed them trying to get up and reached for their neck.

Flaw. The Rose Knights were strong, but a Hob was still stronger. And in the water, they were slow enough to be caught. Pyrite seized the visored head and felt the Rose Knight twisting. Too late.

Second flaw. Everything had to breathe. Pyrite thrust the head *down* and then stepped on the struggling body. He ground the knight into the lake's muddy floor and felt them struggling frantically. All things breathed. Unless they couldn't.

“Chieftain!”

Pyrite's deep voice bellowed across the battlefield, turning Goblin heads. He saw Rags turn to him, eyes wide, and then he lifted the rose shield in his hand. The knight was struggling under his feet, but he was standing on them now.

Rags understood at once. She screamed and horns blew; the Goblins retreated as one towards the lake. But now the Rose Knights were determined to stop them. They formed a line of death and marched into the Goblins, cutting them down, aiming at Rags now. Pyrite groaned. They were going for her! And he couldn't be there to stop them.

He grunted, dove into the water and pushed away a frantic hand. The Rose Knight was still struggling! He—or she—was getting air from somewhere, or they could hold their breath incredibly long. Pyrite surfaced and turned, desperately.

There was only one Goblin who could—where was he? He scanned the battlefield frantically as he put the weakening knight in a headlock underwater.

There. Greybeard was fighting with his old greatsword, laughing as a knight with a battleaxe traded blows with him. But the elderly Hob had dodged every blow. He could—

A dagger stabbed into Pyrite's side, a blade that froze his innards. He gasped and tore the blade out of the knight's hand. He refused to let go, though the knight was pounding on his wound.

Stupid. Should have thought of—Pyrite saw the [Lady] turning her head towards him. Greybeard. He had to be—oh, of course. Why have [Knights] only specialized in swords? Some had bows, others had spells.

Stupid not to think of it.

“Take down that Hob.”

Bethal pointed, and one of the knights by her side abandoned his weapon to draw the bow on his back. The enchanted bowstring *thrummed* once, and the Hob who'd managed to down young Lady Welca Caveis—a knight-errant in training who Bethal had accepted into her ranks—fell, two arrows in his chest. The Rose Knight surged upwards, searching for her

weapons as the Goblins roared and the one on the wolf's back screamed fury and drove her mount into the lake after him.

"Is young Welca alive? Oh, I see she is."

Bethal sighed as the knights around her closed ranks once again. The Goblins had given up assailing her; Thomast's blade and the piles of Goblin bodies had proven the futility of it. And the rest of her warriors were too experienced to be lured into the water like that.

"A pity. That Hob looked almost intelligent."

Thomast turned to her, a hint of reproach in his eyes. Bethal sighed.

"I know. *I know*. But a monster who kills is...we could fish him out afterwards if Welca lets him live. Or maybe—I say, what's going on over there?"

She frowned, and pointed to a spot where Goblins were fighting the Knights of the Petal. Almost all of them had retreated, leaving hundreds of dead bodies behind them. But one Goblin hadn't retreated.

Greybeard had been dueling the Rose Knight with the battleaxe—Sir Kerrig Louis—as soon as he'd crashed into Poisonbite's formation. He alone hadn't been cut down, although the battleaxe's head burned in the open air and Sir Kerrig was a master in using it.

Instead, Greybeard had pushed the Rose Knight back, landing heavy blows on the man's armor and making it ring. The halt in their advance had drawn the attention of the other Knights of the Petal and they'd come to assist Sir Kerrig in dealing with this troublesome foe.

Now there were *six* of the Rose Knights surrounding him as Greybeard struck and countered each blow in a whirlwind of steel. The advance of pink halted and Lady Bethal's eyes widened as she noticed the disturbance.

“Thomast, who is *that* Goblin?”

The Chevalier had no reply, but his eyes narrowed as he saw Greybeard fighting. The other Goblins stopped too, as the old Goblin dodged two blows and countered three at once, his greatsword flashing in a ringing arc. He twisted, and simultaneously countered one blow and parried another. When he spun and kicked, a Rose Knight was knocked off his feet and into the muck.

“Oh dear.”

Lady Bethal’s eyes widened as she saw the Goblin fight. And not just for that. She saw and sensed the battlefield turning against her.

The Goblins of the Flooded Waters tribe stopped their retreat as Greybeard fought. The sense of desperation, of hopelessness that dragged down their limbs evaporated as more and more of them saw the sight of a Goblin who hadn’t fallen. They pointed and roared, and Rags saw a flicker of victory in the darkness.

It was inspiring. A single Goblin held down eight [Knights], forcing them back, his sword singing through the air as he laughed. Pyrite stood in the water, blood dripping from his wounds. Noears found more lightning and hurled it through the air. Goblins stopped retreating and held their ground. How could they not?

They had seen a hero.

On her Carn Wolf, Rags saw the battlefield shift. She raised her sword and screamed.

“Charge! Charge!”

There was no tactic in her words. Rags simply felt a current, far vaster than the one she could create, sweeping her ahead. And as she kicked her mount forwards, her tribe did the same. Goblins streamed across the muddy ground, shouting. They rushed towards the surprised [Knights], ignoring the enchanted blades, pounding on the enchanted armor.

The momentum had turned against the Humans. They backed up rather than be swarmed, forming a wall of steel around their [Lady]. She glared and pointed. Her voice crackled like lightning across the battlefield.

“Thomast!”

And there he was. The [Duelist] at her side strode forwards, and his blade lashed the air. Goblins fell before they drew close to him and then there was a pause in the fighting.

The battered Rose Knights fell back as Greybeard lowered his sword. He wasn't panting, but a light sheen of sweat steamed off his body. Thomast raised his rapier and saluted the Goblin. Greybeard grinned and lifted his greatsword.

They leapt forwards as the Humans and Goblins drew back and met in a clash of blades. Only, there was never any true contact of metal meeting metal. The two struck at each other simultaneously and Thomast's rapier was faster. He flicked the point towards Greybeard's eyes and the Goblin twisted his head around the blade. He cut—impossibly fast for a sword so large—towards Thomast's chest and the [Duelist] stepped back, letting the blade pass a fraction of an inch away from his clothes.

And then they danced. There was no other word for it. Rags had seen the Redfang warriors fight, all precision and grace, but the [Duelist] and Greybeard were on another level entirely. Each strike was so quick and fluid, and led into the next. Rags couldn't imagine herself trying to fight one or the other. She would be dead in the first blow.

But neither one had scored a hit on the other yet. Thomast stepped back, frowning, and then slashed his rapier through the air. There was a good distance between them, but Greybeard twisted his body out of the way. Behind him, a Hob cried out and fell, blood streaming from his chest.

He was cutting the air! Rags' eyes narrowed as she stared at the Human's rapier. Now the [Duelist] cut and Greybeard had to close with him or risk the Goblins behind him taking injuries. So he did, in a lunge that took him low across the ground. And Thomast was waiting.

"[Double Cut]."

As he thrust, a silvery blur struck simultaneously, so that it appeared as if Thomast suddenly had two arms in the place of one for a fraction of a second. Both were aimed at Greybeard's heart and both—missed. The lunging Greybeard vanished, and Thomast turned.

Two Greybeards were standing at his back. They struck simultaneously and the man leapt out of the way, the first ungraceful move to come in the duel. And when he landed, three Greybeards were waiting for him.

Was it an afterimage caused by speed, or a Skill? Rags didn't know, only that Greybeard had suddenly multiplied. A mirage of the old Goblins cut as Thomast backed up, his flickering rapier now on the defensive, warding off the apparitions.

And then—Thomast lunged forwards, shooting across the ground at what had to have been the true Greybeard, his rapier thrusting. It was a lightning-fast blow. And still Greybeard was ready. His greatsword skated down the length of Thomast's rapier and gently, oh so gently opened the man's chest and stomach up in a single strike.

It was elegant and, Rags had to think, intentional. Thomast staggered, turned, and clutched at his chest. Blood streamed from cut arteries and a woman's voice screamed.

“Thomast!”

Bethal rushed forward and so did the Rose Knights. They formed a wall in front of the grinning Greybeard. Only the tip of the Goblin’s greatsword was bloody. Bethal threw herself across her husband’s chest as a knight knelt, fumbling with a healing potion. She shouted as the knights seized the wounded Chevalier.

“Withdraw! Knights, shield my husband with your lives!”

They were retreating? Rags stared in disbelief, but the fallen man was clearly more important than anything else. The [Lady] stood, her riding dress stained with blood, and her eyes were murderous as she stared at the grinning Greybeard. She tossed her head and spoke in the silence.

“Prepare yourselves, Goblins. Tomorrow I return. Flee before then, or I will come back to crush you.”

Then she turned and hurried away with the Knights of the Petal. The Goblins let them go without another word. The cost of a battle was too high and besides—

There was Greybeard.

He stood in the remains of the battlefield, untouched. Where strong Hobs and veteran Goblins had been cut down like wheat he alone was unscathed. Rags rode over to him and noticed how her Carn Wolf shied away from him, refusing to draw near. So she dismounted and strode over to him.

“Chieftain.”

This time the old Hobgoblin didn't bow to her. And Rags was sure he shouldn't. She stared at him, seeing none of the old innocent dementia of age in how he carried himself now. *She had never seen an old Goblin.* She had no idea Goblins could be old. And now she felt like a fool.

“Who are you?”

He just grinned at her. Greybeard turned, planting his sword in the ground and looked.

“Where is Pyrite?”

The Goblins turned. In an instant, they'd located Pyrite. He was being tended to; Rags had used her best healing potions on him, but the two arrows to his chest had come close to his heart. Only his fat had protected him. He staggered upright as Greybeard walked over.

“Old one.”

“Good thought! Smart. You were always smart. But invincible is invincible, eh? Good that you meet Humans like that now rather than later. There are always warriors like that. Should make you train harder, you lazy dreamer, you!”

Greybeard praised Pyrite, patting him affectionately on the head and shoulders as Pyrite grunted softly. Rags had followed the two; all the Goblins had. She waited until Greybeard had turned to ask again.

“Who are you? You are not...”

“Not Greybeard, Chieftain? Not me? I never said who I was. I am just old Goblin. What is surprising about me knowing how to fight?”

The old Goblin spread his hands innocently. Rags narrowed her eyes, taking in the collection of scars across his body. She was angry at being lied to, and perhaps Greybeard saw it.

If he did, he didn't care. She opened her mouth a third time and Greybeard laughed. And the laughter consumed words and sound alike. He walked back to his greatsword and turned. All of the Goblins stared at him. And now he was taller.

"Who am I? I am Greydath."

The name meant nothing to Rags or the other Goblins. Save for Noears. He moaned aloud and fell to his knees. The old Goblin laughed again. He stood tall and his voice echoed in the forest, across the lake. And now he was taller still. A giant contained in a small body.

"In years past they knew me across the world. They shouted my name. Enemies, allies. The world trembled as we built, and then destroyed. And though many have forgotten his face, so long as one Goblin lives, his dream continues. I served Velan the Kind. And he named me his servant of arms."

The old Goblin was decrepit, scarred by thousands of battles, missing most of his teeth. An elderly, battered warrior. And then he drew his sword out of the ground and he was different. His eyes blazed, his smile could eclipse the sun. He raised his blade and Goblins fell to their knees around him. His voice echoed as he raised his sword, proud, unwavering. Another Goblin, dignified, ancient, and as vast as the sky spoke his name to the world.

"I am Greydath of Blades. Once, a Goblin Lord."

He bowed, mockingly, towards Rags. She felt her skin chill and freeze. A low sound swept through the Goblins, like wind, like the heart of a storm.

Here stood a Goblin Lord. Out of nowhere. It was impossible and yet—who could deny it? Surely no other Goblin had his skill, his strength. And no other Goblin could lie, would lie about this.

Something was wrong, though. Rags searched Greydath for any sign that he was who he said he was. And found nothing. He had no pull among the tribe, no mental draw or connection that told her he was her greater. He had no aura that marked him as unique, or even as a Hob. That was something intrinsic to all Goblankind, and he lacked it.

The awe the other Goblins held him in was a product of his might, not anything else. Rags had felt the pull of Chieftains, weak and strong. She felt the distant call of the Goblin Lord, urging her to heed his call. All Goblins called each other, all were connected. But here stood a Goblin Lord, a true Lord, a vassal of the previous Goblin King himself, and she felt nothing.

He...was like a ghost in the world. He didn't *fit* with the others. He didn't pull at her, didn't meld with her being like other Goblins did. Why? Or more probably, how?

Rags narrowed her eyes. She didn't know if this was Greydath's choice or...a consequence of the last Goblin King's death. And yet, she did not doubt for a second he was telling the truth. Greydath stood with his rusted and battered greatsword stuck in the dirt beside him, ragged grey beard waving in the cold wind, and still he crushed everyone with his presence.

But why had he come here—no, why had he revealed himself now of all times? Because the enemy had been too great? From the way he had simply wounded the Chevalier, Rags was certain that wasn't it. She stared at him and forced saliva into a dry mouth.

“Why are you here?”

The old Goblin's wrinkled brows raised. He grinned at her with his remaining teeth.

“To see whether you are worthy.”

“Am I?”

He pondered the question as the hearts of thousands of Goblins thundered in the silence. Here stood a Goblin Lord. And his reply was simple.

“No.”

He shook his head and Rags stood, staring at him. She felt crushed, though it was one word. She felt small and worthless. Greydath looked at her and she was a child, looking up at him.

“Why?”

“You are too young. Too small. Too weak.”

He stooped, bending down to look at her, a kindly Goblin who had brought down empires.

“But most of all? You are not enough.”

“Enough?”

“You do not crush others with who you are. That is all.”

Rags did not understand and Greydath saw it. He turned and raised his sword. His voice echoed across the lake. He swung his blade and there was a tearing sound, a howl. Goblins threw themselves flat. Across the lake, the waters parted, cut by something Rags could not see. They flowed together and Greydath roared.

“Overwhelming! Goblin Lords define themselves by their overwhelming talent! In combat, with sword or axe or bow or magic! With their minds, or hearts! Goblin Lords must stand above all others!”

He swung his weapon again and a tree fell. Hundreds of feet high, it tumbled into the waters. Greydath raised his sword and roared.

“A Goblin Lord rules over other Goblins! They are *unmatched!* I am the greatest of blades, the one who could not be defeated by force of arms! I am Greydath! And you would be a *Lord?* Equal to me?”

Rags couldn’t answer. The air grew tight around her throat and she gasped for air. Greydath laughed and turned away. She coughed, breathing in painfully.

“You. You are not enough, child Chieftain. Tremborag is not enough. He is old, lazy, *fat* on his arrogance. Garen Redfang is complacent in his strength. That is what I see. But I wonder, is the Goblin Lord truly as flawed as others claim?”

“Is he—he—”

Is he like you? Rags could barely breathe. Greydath laughed mockingly again.

“No. He is young. But he must be worthy of his position. But even if he is—I rode with the Goblin King. He is not my equal. And you are not worthy, child! Not yet. None of you are worthy to even remember the face of the Goblin King!”

Where had the kindly old grinning Goblin gone? Greydath swung his sword again and this time Rags felt a hammer drive her flat into the ground. He’d struck *her!* With something—air?

She gasped and curled up into a ball, feeling flashes of pain. Now the other Goblins moved. Instinctively they tried to protect their Chieftain. One paused as he stepped in front of Greydath—the Goblin Lord swung his sword and the Hob flew through the air, crashing into others. Other Goblins surged forwards; Greydath sent them flying or crashing down with casual swings of his sword.

Overwhelming.

“Old one. Stop. Stop.”

Pyrite stumbled forwards. Greydath paused, sword raised.

“Brat.”

Deferentially, Pyrite bowed his head to Greydath as Rags uncurled, gasping.

“Too far. You are too much.”

“I am.”

There was no apology in Greydath’s tone. He turned.

“I am going, young Pyrite. Going to see what the Goblin Lord is. Your Chieftain is too small, yet. She may be something if she grows, maybe not. I will not wait.”

He began to walk away. Rags croaked a word, and then she scrabbled after him. She grabbed Greydath’s foot as he walked away, ignoring the mud that clung to her body. He stopped and stared down at her.

“Why?”

Rags could only say that word. But what she meant was why everything? Why was he in hiding? Why did Pyrite know him? Why had he not—not—

Why had he not led his people as they died? Greydath bent down. His voice was low as he met Rags’ eyes for the first time. She saw sorrow in the depths of his crimson gaze. Sorrow, a burning hatred that had lasted for ages, and something else. Regret?

“Because I cannot be *King*.”

Then he lifted Rags up by one hand and casually tossed her aside. Rags tumbled through the air and landed poorly on the ground. The other Goblins

backed away as Greydath strode through the destroyed camp, out of the forest and into the distance. When Rags picked herself up, he was gone.

The Goblin Lord had been here all along. He had hidden himself, a legend from the past, among them. Poisonbite was almost out of her mind, gnawing at her hand, remembering every time she had been around the old Goblin. And he had stayed in Tremborag's mountain for years! Why?

No one knew. But they had all seen him, all heard his words. Their Chieftain was not ready to become a Goblin Lord. That was natural, perhaps. But to see him and to see the small Goblin who'd picked herself up afterwards—

Overwhelming. That was the word that defined Goblin Lords. So Greydath had said. Overwhelming. He had been unmatched in battle. The Humans who had decimated Rags' careful strategies had broken themselves on his blade. And now he was gone.

The Goblins longed to follow him. Noears was sitting, pale and quiet by the fire. Redscar was staring at his sword, as if he suddenly realized he'd been playing with sticks all his life. The other Goblins were the same. They would have followed his back, abandoned their tribe without a second's thought if he'd but asked. But—

He was like a ghost, like Rags had sensed. He had a physical presence, but no mental connection to the tribe. He had been a Goblin Lord once, yes, but he was not one now.

“Not yet.”

It was Noears who said it first. The other Goblins looked at him. He nodded to Rags. She was sitting where Greydath had tossed her, staring at the ground. He looked around.

“Not yet. Maybe not ever?”

Would that be a bad thing? A Goblin Lord was rare. And yet...Noears was staring at the place where Greydath had stood. His hands were trembling.

“Another tribe could be. Could be—”

A Goblin Lord. The thought made all of them shudder with fear and longing. The Goblin Lord to the south was not worthy, but everything in their nature cried out for one. A Goblin Lord, and a Goblin King. If Rags could not be one, then—

“No.”

A voice spoke. Noears spun. Pyrite stood over them, rubbing at his newly-healed chest. He shook his head.

“Not go. Chieftain is young. Small. But not unworthy.”

His voice gave the other Goblins pause. Yet in the face of what they’d seen—one of Tremborag’s former Hobs raised his voice, speaking in a wheedling, obsequious tone.

“Chieftain is young, yes. But you are strong. One of Greydath’s students? Could be Chieftain?”

The other Goblins held their breaths. He was suggesting treason. Pyrite stared blankly at the Hob, and then raised his hand. He made a fist and punched at the Hob’s head.

The other Hob was a warrior, and a good one. He raised his arm, yelping denials. He was going to block. So Pyrite changed the angle and arc

of his punch mid-blow. He casually walloped the other Hob in the head without missing a beat. The sound was heavy and satisfying, but the blow itself made all the other Goblins gape. Across the camp, several Redfang warriors sat up with interest. Redscar stared at Pyrite, impressed.

“Good punch.”

Pyrite shrugged as the other Hob toppled over. Redscar stared at the fallen Hob and narrowed his eyes.

“Greybeard—Greydath teach you anything?”

The big Hob paused. He shrugged impassively, not a flicker of emotion crossing his face. He was either simple as he seemed or—the other Goblins recalled Greybeard’s false persona—a truly magnificent actor. Pyrite scratched at his belly as he replied to Redscar.

“Teach some. Some. Important things, not important things. Some.”

The other Goblins looked at each other.

“How much?”

Pyrite shrugged again.

“Not much. Old things. Stories. But I left mountain long ago. Made own tribe. Long past.”

He flicked his hand and no one bought it for a second. Poisonbite narrowed her eyes.

“Rags beat your tribe.”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Lots of arrows. Can’t dodge good. Plus—Garen Redfang. Good not to fight, I think.”

Pyrite steadily returned her gaze. He turned and bowed his head.

“Chieftain.”

Rags stood behind the Hob, small, looking pale. The other Goblins hesitated a second before getting to their feet. And she saw it. Rags stared at Pyrite, and then at the other Goblins.

“Not yet.”

She said the words bitterly. None of the other Goblins could look her in the eye. Save for Pyrite. He nodded and moved on.

“Chieftain, Humans are coming back. What to do?”

She blinked at him. The listening Goblins blinked at him. But Pyrite just waited, patiently as ever, for Rags’ orders.

The small Goblin hesitated. She scuffed at the ground.

“Should run.”

“Humans hunt.”

Pyrite pointed that out and she glared at him. Rags opened her mouth to tell him fighting was impossible, that Greydath had been the only one who could fight! Then her eyes caught something at Pyrite’s side. She stared.

“Broken axe.”

He blinked and looked down. The axe Rags had given him—her first gift to any of her followers after the raid with Tremborag—had broken. He lifted it and shrugged.

“Sorry.”

He handed it to her and Rags stared at the broken metal and wood. She looked around. The forest was full of trees. Tall ones. And yet, Greydath had toppled one in an instant. She stared at the fallen tree, and the Goblins saw something flicker across her face. The small Goblin was small. But then she smiled and she was a bit taller.

Their Chieftain turned to face the others and lifted the axe in her hands. She hefted it with a grunt and looked towards the trees.

“Get cutting. We do not run. We prepare.”

The Goblins looked at her and then at each other. Then they stood up. Pyrite spoke for all of them.

“Yes, Chieftain.”

The next day, forty Rose Knights, Lady Bethal, and the Chevalier Thomast stopped in the same spot and saw the Goblins had not fled. If they had it wouldn't have mattered; the Knights of the Petal were as adept at fighting on horseback as they were on foot. That they had to dismount to maneuver in the forest mattered not at all.

However, one thing had changed. Lady Bethal's brows rose as she saw a few trees had been felled in the interior of the forest. And out of the wood the Goblins had built—

“A fortress.”

Thomast had healed from his wounds of yesterday, but still Bethal had refused to let him be first into combat. Should the Goblin with the greatsword appear again this time, he would be dealt with by others. The Rose Knights would surround the old Goblin and wear him down with

numbers and magical artifacts instead. Only, it seemed that rather than send their champion out and base their strategy around him this time, the Goblins had been building.

A wall of wood, a mighty barricade from which Goblins could repel any attacking force. There were four such walls, each one twenty feet in height, forming a box amid the trees. There the Goblins had decided to make their stand, in their fortress of wood amid mud and snow. It was a worthy place to be besieged from. Bethal could spot more Goblins behind the walls, ready to hold it for as long as it took. She sighed and shook her head.

“How ingenious. They did that in one day? I would say it is commendable—but I won’t. Thomast? Destroy the walls.”

Her Chevalier nodded. Reluctantly, Bethal thought. Even after he’d been nearly killed—her heart beat faster in fury. He was too kind. He nodded at one of the Rose Knights standing next to him. The Goblins watched, curious. They had heavy shields on their walls and barriers made of thick wood. They were probably confident they could withstand however many arrows the Rose Knights had brought.

One of the Knights of the Petal who looked less bulky than the others raised a staff in his pink, gauntleted hands and pointed it towards the walls. He spoke a single word, pointed. One of the Goblins on the walls with no ears shouted an alarm—

Too late. The [Grand Fireball] spell shot through the forest and burst across the walls. Goblins screamed and disappeared into an inferno and the flash and smoke blinded everyone for a second. When it was over, a huge hole had opened up in the thick walls and thousands of Goblins were suddenly afforded a spectacular view of the Rose Knights. And vice versa.

“[Knights] can be [Mage Knights] too, little Goblins. Advance!”

Bethal's voice snapped and the Rose Knights charged once more. They raced towards the Goblins who met them with a roar. Only, now they were boxed in, trapped by the fortress they had worked so hard to design! The Rose Knights charged towards them, intent on holding them in place and capitalizing on this mistake.

The ruse lasted until the first pink knight was nearly upon her Goblins. Rags, sitting on one of the back walls, gave the order. She raised her hand and Pyrite pointed. Goblins hidden behind one of the huge trees saw the signal and *pushed*.

Goblins and trees. Of course, they'd cut a few down to build this stupid little fort, but they'd spent the rest of that time carefully, *carefully* sawing at the base of the trees, making sure they were still standing upright, but able to be *pushed*—

The first tree, an ancient guardian hundreds of years old, fell with a thundering crash upon the Rose Knights. They cried out, unprepared for a few thousand pounds of wood to hit them. Rags clenched her fist as two of the Knights went down, pinned by the branches. And one more had been directly hit! She shouted in celebration—

Until she saw the knight was *still* moving. Weakly, yes, but the impact had only dented their armor. Rags stared. The other Knights were lifting at the tree, trying to recover their comrade—

“Next tree.”

She pointed to Pyrite. He nodded and pointed to two more trees. The Hobs and Goblins hiding behind them *heaved* and down the trees went. It

was hard to aim them, of course, but it was fortunate the pink knights were such a colorful target.

One huge tree was aimed straight at Lady Bethal. She blinked at it. Ten of her Rose Knights roared as they leapt towards the tree. They braced themselves and *caught* the tree as it fell towards them. Rags gaped.

“More trees!”

Four more trees were toppled, but the Rose Knights were retreating out of the forest now. Two of their comrades lay on the ground—unconscious or dead, it was hard to tell. Some of the other Rose Knights had dented armor.

It was a paltry victory in Rags’ mind, but the Goblins around her cheered wildly to see the invincible Humans retreat. And without Greybeard! She could see them staring at her, and sat a bit straighter.

Overwhelming. She knew she was weak as a warrior, but her mind? Rags narrowed her eyes. What would the Human [Lady] do next? Burn the forest down? Attack from afar? Rags had prepared herself for everything, but she was still not ready for what Lady Bethal did next.

“That little minx.”

Bethal narrowed her eyes as she stared at the downed trees and eyed the Goblin fortress. She couldn’t spot the Goblin Chieftain this time; if she had, she might have had her shot from afar, never mind Thomast’s objections.

One of her Rose Knights who’d survived having a tree dropped on him saluted her. His helmet was dented and he was unsteady, but his voice was clear and worried.

“Milady, they are attempting to surround our position.”

He pointed to the Goblins as they streamed slowly out of the forest. Did they have another plan or was this a feint? Were the two of her [Knights] alive? Bethal’s heart ached and her head hurt trying to figure out what might happen next.

“Sir Resip, it seems we’ve been caught off-guard. What do you propose we do? If the Goblins can take out two of my Knights of the Petal, is it worth risking more of your lives?”

He bowed, fearless, wobbling only a bit as he straightened.

“My Lady Bethal, we do not fear death when valor awaits! Only give the word and we will slay the leader of these Goblins. With your permission, we can retreat with you to a defensible location while a core of us strike at the Goblin Chieftain. If we kill her, the rest of the Goblins will lose their command—”

“No.”

Bethal said it suddenly and decisively. Sir Resip and the other Rose Knights stared at her. He wavered.

“Milady?”

Lady Bethal looked at the two Knights pinned underneath the tree, thought of the old Goblin, and looked at the Chevalier Thomast. Her voice held a note of complaint in it as she addressed her husband.

“Thomast, I’m not in the mood to hunt Goblins any longer. Let’s go home.”

He blinked at her. Bethal stared back. Thomast turned.

“Sound the retreat.”

The Goblins wavered when they heard the horn call and saw the line of pink knights moving backwards in tight formation. Rags frowned as she saw Lady Bethal unhook one of her earrings—she'd worn *earrings* to a battlefield—and lightly touch the gem. She began speaking into the gemstone, and part of what she said drifted through the wind and was picked up by Rags' keen ears. And the ears of the rest of the Goblins.

"Magnolia? It's me. Yes, Bethal. I'm not hunting the Goblins anymore. What? No, I see them. They're right in front of me. But I'm giving up. Okay? Wait—stop shouting!"

There was a pause as Bethal listened to someone on the other end. Rags' jaw dropped slowly. Bethal's voice rose, indignant.

"I lost *two* of my Rose Knights. Two! You said they'd be easy to—no, don't shout at me! There were unforeseen circumstances that—how many were killed? A few hundred...maybe a thousand. Yes, there are lots more. No, I'm not doing it! There's too much risk and I don't feel like it. Yes, *I don't feel like it*. I'm going back to my estate. Send a carriage to—hello? Hello?"

She threw the earring to the ground and stomped on it. Thomast bent to pick the earring up from the frosted ground. Bethal tossed her head angrily.

"The nerve of that woman! I was about to tell her about that old Goblin—not that he was that much of a threat. You underestimated him, Thomast."

"I did not."

She stomped her foot.

"Yes you did! I keep telling you not to and you do! You could have beaten him—"

"He reminds me of an old story."

“Hm?”

Thomast straightened, cleaning the earring with a handkerchief one of the Rose Knights offered him. He watched the unmoving Goblins over Bethal’s shoulder as he spoke.

“During the Second Antinium War, there were mighty Goblin Lords. Each known for their abilities in some way or another. One was known as the greatest warrior, someone whose skill at arms let him cut the air itself, a Goblin who could match any [Blademaster], any [Sword Dancer] or [Duelist]. He was called Greydath, I think. Greydath of Blades. That old Goblin reminded me of him.”

Bethal stared at her consort for a second and then burst out laughing. She patted his arm lightly, chuckling and wiping tears from her eyes.

“Don’t be silly, Thomast. The Goblin Lords all died out. They fell when their King did, or led their armies into oblivion shortly thereafter. He’s just an old Goblin. A veteran of the Goblin Wars, perhaps. You *are* prone to your silliness, aren’t you?”

“My apologies, milady.”

He bowed to her and she pouted.

“Call me ‘my dear’, or ‘wife’, or *Bethal*. Oh, Thomast, I’m feeling invigorated after all that fighting. I don’t know how I’ll explain the loss of two of my Rose Knights to Magnolia or their families. Comfort me?”

She clung to him. Thomast shook his head.

“Not here.”

She sighed.

“Prudish. Do be a dear and find us a nice deserted house so we can be alone. Or a tent. Or a bush. Or we can just find some grass and order

everyone to look away.”

He smiled and lifted her into his arms as the other Knights of the Petal coughed or looked away. Slowly, Thomast turned and, still carrying Lady Bethal, he began to march with the other knights into the distance. It was as if the Goblins had completely been forgotten by all of them.

Chivalry, valor, passion, and dignit—and virtu—and nobility. Such were the aspects that governed Lady Bethal and her house. The Rose Knights marched away as the Lady of House Walchaís let her husband carry her off into the distance. The Goblins of the Flooded Waters tribe watched them go in silence. Rags closed her mouth after a while and looked around.

Blood and death remained. The scars of battle were fresh in the memories of the Goblins; they had burnt their dead out of respect. And there were fallen on Bethal’s side. Yet the lady turned away. And there was something admirable about that, as insane as she clearly was. She lived for her whims. And there it was. Valor, passion, pride—it was something like that.

Rags scratched her head. Goblin Lords and [Ladies]. Pink knights. She really wished Erin were here to explain things to her.

“House Walchaís? Um...they’re one of the larger houses in Izril. They’re not one of the Five Families, obviously, but they came soon after the original noble families did and they can trace their roots back to Terandria.”

Lyonette paused and looked up. She was scrubbing the bar with Erin, a rare moment when the two of them could chat. She frowned, her forehead wrinkling as she tried to answer Erin’s question precisely.

“They’re mad as loons, all of them. They’re the kind of nobility who love to go on quests, and who train [Knights] and duel people over insults. From what I can remember...Lady Bethal Walchaís is the current scion of the house. She married a famous [Duelist] after eloping with him and then came back to establish her own branch of [Knights] and take control of her family. She’s arrogant, prickly, and her husband has killed twelve people in duels of honor.”

Erin blinked as she raised her wet dust rag and scrubbed at a stain.

“Whoa. That’s a lot. I think. Is it? No—twelve people? That’s a lot.”

“And those are just the ones killed, remember. Lady Bethal has many friends, but many more enemies.”

Lyonette grimaced and took a drink of cold water before wiping away a bead of sweat. Now it was coming back to her, all the little squabbles and ever-shifting networks of names and political alliances. She smiled as she recalled something Erin might like.

“She’s also known for her flights of passion. Did you know she once bought five hundred prime horses to establish her own horse breeding industry? Only, within a month she’d gotten bored so she fenced off twenty thousand acres of land and let them roam wild. They kept repopulating until there were so many that her lands became famous for exporting war stallions anyways.”

“Whoa. Hey, how do you know all of this? Do you know these Wal—Wallchase people personally?”

The [Princess] turned [Barmaid] rolled her eyes and laughed.

“Erin, I was a [Princess] who took part in the politics of the realm. I *have* to remember all of it. Only, I was a bad student so my tutors always despaired. I suppose memorizing orders as a [Barmaid] helped my memory.

But why do *you* want to know about House Walchaís anyways? Do you have an issue with them or know them somehow?”

Erin opened her mouth and frowned.

“You know what? I have no idea. Oh. Right! I didn’t mean to say *Walchaís*, I meant to say Welch’s juice. You know—grape juice? Oh right, you don’t know. Anyways, they make grape juice. I wish I had some.”

Lyonette stared at her. Erin stared back and then raised her hands.

“Right! Back to work!”

They went back to cleaning the tables. After a while, Lyonette raised her head.

“I wonder if there are any vineyards around here. Terandria has a lot, but do Drakes or Gnolls raise grapes? Do they even grow in this climate?”

Erin frowned.

“Good question.”

They stared at each other and shrugged. The Goblins were downstairs, sleeping off a food coma, the inn was quiet, and for the moment there was tenuous peace. After a while, Mrsha rolled across the floor, chewing on a magic wand.

It was a relief to have a peaceful day in the inn. Especially after all the trouble with the Goblins they’d had. And all the trouble they were about to have. Erin shook her head.

“I sort of wish I was with Rags right now. I bet she’s keeping nice and quiet, you know, keeping her head down while all this Goblin Lord business sorts itself out? She’s smart.”

She tapped her head. Lyonette nodded obligingly.

Mrsha sneezed.

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Beneath Liscor, the war continued. It was a quiet war, one that the Drakes and Gnolls living above were unaware of. It had gone on for years; it could rightly be called a war of attrition, although neither side truly viewed it as such. How could a war of attrition take place when both sides were functionally inexhaustible?

The Hive of the Free Antinium versus the monsters of Liscor's dungeon. Both groups were able to reproduce at speeds that allowed them to continually clash with one another. The monsters in Liscor's dungeon were numerous and had established vast nests within the dungeon. The groups that continually assailed the Antinium Hive were a drop in an ocean of bodies. So long as they were not purged in their homes, they would keep coming.

On the other end, the Antinium were adept at repopulating themselves. They had developed it into a science, such that they could weather any number of losses with few issues. After all, so long as their Prognugator and, more importantly, Queen survived, what were the deaths of a few hundred Soldiers that died to stop a group of Flesh Worms, or the Workers who perished each day rebuilding their tunnels and fortifications?

Neither side cared. Not the Queen and certainly not the monsters. But if anyone had bothered to ask the Workers and Soldiers, they would have said...

Nothing. Soldiers did not speak and Workers had few opinions of their own. They were born loyal to their Hive and fought and died in service to it. What was despair to a being that had been alive for hours? New Soldiers hurried to the front lines, fighting monsters with the fluids of their creation

still wet on their carapaces. They were faceless, voiceless. And alone. There was no one to champion them.

In a section of tunnels adjacent to the dungeon, a group of Soldiers struggled alone. They fought desperately against an equal number of enchanted suits of armor. These metal guardians were the equals of Soldiers; incredibly tough and difficult to kill, they cut down the Antinium one by one as the Soldiers hurled themselves desperately against their foe. The newly born Soldiers fell back, desperate. Fighting. Dying.

And yet they fought on. Because if they fled, who would fight? The Soldiers ignored the wounds on their bodies, and yet despair crept into their limbs, weighing them down. They cried out, silently, without a voice to speak, without words or knowledge of what they wished for. They needed someone to give them hope, to give them a reason to fight. Someone, something they could believe in. In their darkest moments the knowledge of their Hive was not enough. They needed—

One of the suits of armor bashed a Soldier down with a mace. It strode forwards, red light leaking through the slits in its visor as the enchanted guardians approached. A Soldier raised a broken arm as the other three battered the armor of its foe futilely. He knew he was going to die and the knowledge was bitter and cold. But then he heard a different sound.

Click.

It was thunderous, collective, a sound made of many parts. A hundred mandibles snapped together. The enchanted armor paused, and the Soldier heard it again.

Click.

This time the echo was louder, and there was a drumming noise, the sound of heavy footfalls. The Soldier stumbled backwards through the tunnel and saw something running towards him.

A foe? No. Another Antinium. But this one was different from the Soldiers and Workers, the faceless multitudes. It was...bigger? Bigger, yes, a bit. But what set this Antinium apart was the *color*.

Yellow splatters of paint covered the Soldier who ran down the tunnel towards the enchanted suits of armor. They turned, weapons covered with green Antinium blood. The mace-wielding armor turned towards the Soldier, weapon ready. It swung and the young Soldier tried to look away rather than see this new Soldier cut down—

The mace struck the Soldier with yellow splatters on one raised forearm. The chitin *cracked* under the force of the mighty blow, but unlike the other Antinium who had broken from the crushing impact, this Soldier's body was tougher. Two of his arms shot out, pinning the arms of the enchanted suit of armor. The other two began to pound it, making the ancient steel *ring* with the impacts.

The other Soldiers stared. The enchanted suits of armor abandoned their foes to help their comrade, but now more Soldiers were streaming through the tunnels. The Soldier with the broken arm stared. These Antinium were like the one who had charged into battle. They were all painted, all colorful! One had a star on its forehead, another a rainbow of droplets all over its body, like rain.

They were all unique, all—all different. And as they charged down the corridor, the young Soldier saw an Antinium holding a strange object that released plumes of sweet smoke every time he shook it. The Worker pulled the Soldier with the broken arm out of the battle, shielding them as the colorful Soldiers charged ahead. And the young Soldier now had an image, a name for what he had cried out for in his last moments.

He stared at the Soldier with yellow splatters as he pointed and the other Soldiers charged ahead. Yes, that was what he'd wanted. Someone to lead them, to show them—hope. He had no words for what he felt, for what the

other Soldier was. But if he had heard the word, he would have agreed with it immediately. The other Antinium were different, braver, more certain, and they fought for something rather than because they had been told. They were unique. They were hope.

They were heroes.

Yellow Splatters ran down the tunnel, his legs pumping as his arms rose. He didn't feel the cracked chitin on his arm. He was alight with battle fury. And each second he ran was another second, another life he could have saved. He charged into the backs of the second group of monsters on the front lines and caught a suit of armor with a two-armed lariat. He flung the hundreds of pounds of armor to the ground and began stomping on the metal guardian, ignoring the other suits of armor as they turned towards him.

Enchanted armor this time. At least they didn't seem to be accompanied by any other types of monsters. Yellow Splatters had learned to dread monsters working in tandem with each other. At least the enchanted suits of armor were few in number.

But deadly. This corridor was filled with the bodies of Soldiers and Workers alike. Yellow Splatters had arrived too late. He gave vent to his fury as the other suits of armor assailed him. They cut at his body, struck him with metal fists, and tried to bear him down. But Yellow Splatters refused to fall. He couldn't.

He was a [Sergeant]. The Soldier felt another part of his outer layer of chitin *crack* as something struck him in the shoulder. But the blade that cut

into his side, the fist that smashed him in the side of the head, none of those blows could fell him. He had a Skill. [Tough Carapace].

One Skill, but it made so much of a difference. And another—Yellow Splatters turned and his fist sent a metal suit of armor flying with a dent in the chest plate.

[Power Strike]. The other suits of armor closed in, fearless. Yellow Splatters raised his arms to guard his body and saw one of the suits of armor disappear. A Soldier had crashed into it with a running tackle. This Soldier had white wings painted on his back and he rolled around on the ground, bashing the armor's helmet in.

The other Soldiers had arrived. Yellow Splatters abandoned his guard and leapt into the attack again. He and another Soldier tore the arms off a suit of armor, and then he found himself bashing at another suit with the arm he'd ripped off. And then?

It was all over. At least, for now. Yellow Splatters rose, breathing heavily, and heard a voice.

“Sergeant Yellow Splatters, we are ordered to take Tunnel E4J!”

He turned and saw a smaller Antinium standing at the back of the group of Soldiers. Pawn, censer in hand, was bending over a wounded Soldier. Yellow Splatters rose and immediately pointed. The Soldiers under his command—forty of them—raced down the tunnel.

War. That was what he fought. Yellow Splatters slammed into another group of monsters—large maggots that spat acid at him, and then found himself fighting a horrific moth that was so large it had to crawl down the tunnel. The Face-Eater Moth, one of the large insects that the dungeon housed, ripped off a Soldier's arm and buried its mandibles in another before it died.

Both had been marked. After the giant moth was dead, Yellow Splatters stood over the dead Soldier. His body had been shredded, but Yellow Splatters could remember what had been drawn on his chest. A white circle with a question mark drawn on the inside. In black paint. Yellow Splatters didn't know what it meant, but that wasn't important. It had defined that Soldier.

And now he was dead. The symbol would be redrawn on the walls of the barracks. He would be remembered so long as the walls and the Soldiers living within remained—but the Soldier was dead.

In the aftermath of the battle, as the remaining monsters retreated back to the dungeon or were finished off, Yellow Splatters found Pawn again. The Worker was standing with two other Workers, both of whom were poring over maps of the Hive's tunnels. These maps were a new thing; all Antinium knew the layout of the Hive through the collective mental link they shared, and their Queen knew all, so what would be the purpose of maps? But these two Antinium were [Strategists], and they had insisted on the need to make them.

Belgrade and Anand, the two coordinators of the Hive's defenses, were speaking with Pawn as Yellow Splatters waited to be given orders. The fact that they were Workers and he was a Soldier was important; they could talk and he could not. Thus, they gave orders to the Soldiers, and Yellow Splatters, the highest-level and only leader among the Soldiers, was often tasked with implementing commands.

He led the Individual Soldiers, the ones who had marked themselves with paint and begun to level within the Hive. They were a small unit assigned to Pawn, but they were growing and they had distinguished themselves in battle, holding ground and defeating monsters with far fewer casualties than regular Soldiers and Workers.

But the casualties did occur. Each day, there was usually one death. On bad days, there were more. And of late—Yellow Splatters ached inside, remembering the deaths. Holding the dungeon against the influx of monsters who attacked regularly was difficult, but it had been harder of late as well. In fact, the Workers were discussing that very issue now.

“We have held the tunnels nearest the lowest southeastern breach into the dungeon. Casualties were...minimal given the attack. I regret that my static defenses were overwhelmed. Thankfully Anand had already redirected your division, Pawn. And there have been no other attacks today.”

Belgrade was pointing to a map. Yellow Splatters knew he was pointing to the location he had just been in. He stared at Belgrade.

It was a new idea, to think of each Antinium as separate. A few weeks ago Yellow Splatters would not have been able to understand the concept. But now he did, and he had already begun to appreciate the difference between Belgrade and Anand. Both had taken over for Klbkch and the Queen in leading the defense of the Hive, usually from the dungeon attacks. And both had different styles.

Belgrade was a fan of fixed formations, of chokepoints and static groups of Soldiers who would hold a particular tunnel while he reinforced areas at risk at need. By contrast, Anand seldom kept Soldiers and Workers under his command in one place. He preferred to send roving strike forces out to attack monsters, usually choosing to ambush them or attack from all sides with superior numbers.

Apparently, that preference for strategy was derived from the games of chess both played, and Yellow Splatters understood that Anand was considered the better player—and [Tactician]—of the two.

He agreed. Yellow Splatters had developed opinions in the time since he had become [Sergeant], and one of his opinions was that Belgrade's method of defending was too costly. If a powerful monster—like one of the giant Face-Eater Moths, or a Crypt Worm—attacked, regular Soldiers would be quickly killed. By contrast, luring the enemy and setting up tactically advantageous situations was infinitely better and saved lives.

That wasn't to say that Yellow Splatters didn't appreciate the need for Belgrade—he was efficient at intercepting smaller monsters or ones that tried to dig into the Hive. But wherever possible, Yellow Splatters would prefer Anand to lead. And that was often the case when both [Tacticians] were on duty and neither one was injured.

So *why* had today's battle seen Belgrade take the lead? Two tunnels had been overrun by monsters, two tunnels that were practically entering into the dungeon. They were *not* the usual areas of conflict.

"It seems like the radius at which monsters will begin to attack each other is indeed around four thousand paces from the dungeon's outer walls. As you said, Anand."

Belgrade turned to the other Worker, who nodded. Anand's voice was different from Belgrade's. While both had the same body, Anand spoke more confidently to the softer voice Belgrade had.

"Indeed. Holding these areas—"

He touched on four spots on the map, each one indicating an entrance from the dungeon into the Hive through a collapsed wall or open breach in the dungeon.

"—is far more costly than if we pulled back. Redirecting the monsters into kill zones where they become aware of each other and reduce their numbers is the most expedient strategy."

Precisely put. Yellow Splatters shifted from one foot to another. His upper right arm—the one he'd used to block a mace earlier—was dripping blood from between the cracks. Since it was the only wound he'd taken and very minor, he ignored it and the pain. He waited, trying to understand *why* no one was listening to Anand's sensible advice. Why were they so close to the dungeon, taking casualties? Was this Belgrade's idea? It was foolish. Stupid.

Wrong. Yellow Splatters thought the word deliberately, although he couldn't speak it. Belgrade nodded.

"I think it will be difficult to hold this area. But of course, we must. For now, I recommend doubling the Soldiers guarding each entrance, and keeping PaintedAntinium in reserve. Pawn, how many of your Soldiers can you spare?"

Pawn hesitated and glanced at Yellow Splatters for the first time. The [Sergeant] willed Pawn to give the correct answer.

Colored Antinium. That was what the two [Tacticians] had begun calling the Soldiers with paint. As if they were...different. And they were. They were elite warriors, in a Hive where there had been only uniformity before. They were few, though. And growing fewer. It was hard to show a Soldier what it meant to be Individual, and daily losses meant they were slowly losing more than they converted. Yellow Splatters thought on that often.

"...I can spare twenty, I think, Belgrade. I would like to rest the injured, and if I am not here to pray for the wounded, casualties seem to—"

Belgrade was already nodding his agreement. Neither he nor Anand ever really contradicted Pawn, except in matters of strategy. The sole [Acolyte] and first Worker to become Individual was deeply respected by

all of the Antinium. Yellow Splatters considered Pawn a fine helper. But he was not a leader.

At least he had given a good number. Twenty. Yellow Splatters had a running tally of wounded Soldiers under his commands and the ones who were tired from battle. Twenty to be sent for active duty left a margin of around...sixty three for emergencies and tomorrow's combat. Acceptable.

"Agreed, then. Send them here and I will keep them in reserve. No sense losing any if it can be avoided."

Belgrade was speaking to the others. His words made Yellow Splatters...hurt. What he said was, of course, correct, but by preserving the lives of the valuable Individual Soldiers, he was sacrificing more regular Soldiers instead. To Yellow Splatters, any Soldier's death was unacceptable. He had been a regular Soldier, once. Now he was a leader, *the* leader of Soldiers. He would save them all if he could.

And indeed, as the Workers turned they had to look up at him. Yellow Splatters was a Soldier and taller than Workers, but he was actually taller than other Soldiers as well. Just by an inch or two, and his body was a tiny bit larger, but it was noticeable given the uniformity of other Antinium. Pawn had speculated that it was a product of his leader class. Yellow Splatters felt it was a mark of rank.

"Sergeant Yellow Splatters, thank you for your efforts. I believe today's wave will be all for the next four hours at least. The dungeon seems to influence monsters to attack at semi-predictable intervals...you may rest for now."

Yellow Splatters nodded his head towards Anand, deliberately shifting his body so he wasn't nodding at Belgrade. If the other Worker noticed it... no, he did not. He was still looking over the maps.

Holding the tunnels closest to the dungeon. Why? They should be fighting in the more distant tunnels and blocking these ones with dirt to slow the monsters as they burrowed to the Hive. Yellow Splatters fumed as he marched back with Pawn towards the other Soldiers. They were all waiting for him and all, save for their one fallen brother, relatively unharmed. There would be no need for the precious few healing potions that Pawn had been given by Klbkch.

“Yellow Splatters, let us return. I would like to speak with you in the barracks.”

Pawn deferentially let Yellow Splatters proceed in front of him. Yellow Splatters pointed, and the Soldiers formed up into a double line and marched out of the distant tunnels and back towards the heart of the Hive.

The [Sergeant] tried to grapple with his anger as he marched down the main tunnels, letting Workers move quickly out of his way. However, emotion was a rare feeling for him. It was practically unheard of among Soldiers. But Yellow Splatters had begun having opinions. Again, it was probably part of his class, but those opinions made him question things.

Things like his place, orders he'd been given, and certain things Pawn said. Of course, it was necessary for Soldiers to fight, and guarding the dungeon was essential to preserve the Hive. Yellow Splatters was loyal to his Queen, despite never having seen her. But orders that wasted lives, like the ones Belgrade had given and continued to give? Hold the entrances? Why? Yellow Splatters disagreed with those orders.

And sometimes, with Pawn. Yellow Splatters turned his body as he walked to look back at Pawn. The Worker was maintaining the censer he'd used, cleaning it of incense as he walked. He was important. He had given Yellow Splatter identity, promoted him to [Sergeant]. But he did not understand war and battle by his own admission. And yet, he commanded the Soldiers?

Was that wrong? Yellow Splatters turned forwards and noticed the staring. Soldiers and Workers alike had paused in their endless commute to stare at him and the other Colored Antinium. They usually did, but today Yellow Splatters sensed that most of the gazes were on *him*.

Because of his height. Of course. It was probably less than an inch—more like a few centimeters. In a crowd of Drakes, Gnolls, Humans, or any other race it would have been completely unnoticed. But among the Antinium it was like someone was shining a beacon on Yellow Splatters.

He stood tall as he marched towards his barracks. He was not proud; that was a foreign emotion to him when Pawn had explained it to him. Rather, Yellow Splatters was dedicated. He fought enemies. He killed to save as many of his fellow Soldiers as possible. He mourned the deaths of his comrades and strove to level up further, to become stronger in order to save more. That was all that there was to live for. All that was meaningful.

The barracks of the Individual Soldiers had changed in several ways since Pawn had first wandered into it. It had been expanded and given several access points for convenience and a speedier connection to the front lines in the Hive. Space had also been cleared on one wall for a...mural of sorts.

Symbols decorated the wall, each with their own space, but each close enough so that it seemed they formed a pattern. The marks of fallen Soldiers rested there. Yellow Splatters looked up and saw patterns he recognized.

A paw print in white. Eight lines and a curvy wave. A golden quartet of stars. So many already. And a Soldier was already dipping his finger in

white paint, drawing out the circle and question mark onto the wall.

It hurt. But Yellow Splatters embraced this pain. It was right that the wall be here, reminding the Soldiers of who they had lost, who they had sacrificed. This is why they fought. For the Hive, for the Queen, but for each other above all else.

A few more details of the changed barracks caught Yellow Splatters' eye as he turned from the mural. There was now a storage area in the barracks, a place where a small crate of healing potions had been placed, a stockpile of bandages and other healing agents usually reserved for the most wounded of Antinium—

And in one corner, slightly dusty from lack of use, a pile of books. They had been Pawn's latest addition to the barracks.

No one had touched them. Yellow Splatters stared at the books. He considered them a waste of space. He understood—vaguely—that these books had images in them and were meant to tell stories like the ones Pawn told to the Soldiers each night. However, what was the point?

Stories were fine for helping new Soldiers become Individual. But they were not practical, not *useful* for Soldiers who were already Individual. If a Soldier had realized his potential, it was more important to do other things.

Like train. Yellow Splatters strode over to a cleared area in the barracks where several Soldiers were already sparring. It was an unheard-of idea for Soldiers, but once Pawn had suggested the idea, Yellow Splatters had immediately seen it was one of the Worker's *good* suggestions.

The Soldiers were fighting in pairs and sometimes in groups. It could be a duel between two Soldiers, but since battle was rarely that fair, sometimes there were as many as five Soldiers beating on one. Not hitting with full force, of course; that would be too dangerous. But they swung fast and hard

enough to sometimes crack chitin, dodging, punching, learning to fight more efficiently.

A Soldier approached as Yellow Splatters walked into the sparring area. He was a new Soldier, one with a pink stripe on either side of his face. Twin Stripes raised his four fists, each one a bludgeoning tool that could gouge, grab, or bludgeon as necessary. Yellow Splatters raised his own arms and the two Soldiers charged towards each other.

At first, Twin Stripes went to grab Yellow Splatters, but the [Sergeant] punched him back. Twin Stripes circled, lashing out with careful punches and keeping two arms back for a guard. Yellow Splatters ignored defense and went for a full-out assault. He—gently—hammered Twin Stripes, dominating his opponent. Despite that, Twin Stripes kept fighting, doggedly avoiding blows and blocking where he could until Yellow Splatters decided it was time to rest.

Exhausted, the new Soldier lowered his guard. The exchange of blows had been intense, and the carapace on his upper right arm and shoulder was slightly cracked. Nevertheless, he was ready for Yellow Splatters to continue.

Good! Yellow Splatters radiated approval and the other Soldiers sensed it. This is what was important. Not *books*, not stories—this was practical. Aside from rest and food, this was all a Soldier needed. Because the next battle would be upon them soon, and when it occurred, Yellow Splatters wanted his unit as prepared as they could be for it.

...Oddly, it seemed fewer of them were leveling up as fast as they used to be. Of course, higher levels meant they slowed down, but even Yellow Splatters was only a Level 12 [Sergeant]. The other Soldiers should be leveling faster, not slower.

He wondered why that was. Maybe the training was too light? But full-power blows were too dangerous. Well, at least the Soldiers were learning to fight in their off-time. Yellow Splatters beckoned to three Soldiers, wanting to increase the intensity of his sparring, when he heard a voice.

“Sergeant?”

Pawn. Yellow Splatters paused and reluctantly turned. The Worker was waiting for him next to the pile of books. The Soldier trotted over and noticed Pawn carefully dusting the books off, arranging them to face the barracks. He stared at the books and then at the Worker, impatiently.

“I mourn the loss of one of our Soldiers. I prayed...but my prayers do not always work. Nevertheless, thank you for fighting as you did. Those Soldiers might have been slaughtered had you not charged in.”

The Worker looked up at Yellow Splatters and he nodded. Pawn always thanked Yellow Splatters and the other Soldiers after a battle. However, this time the Worker hesitated. He clicked his mandibles lightly together and made a weak clicking sound—the Antinium equivalent of clearing his throat.

“I wonder, though, if you are not becoming too brave, Yellow Splatters? It was a very risky maneuver you made. Brave, yes, and it did save lives, but it put you in great danger.”

The [Sergeant] stared at Pawn uncomprehendingly. Of course he had been in danger, charging ahead of the others. Shouldn’t he risk his life?

Pawn seemed to understand his point. He usually did. The Worker nodded his head, clutching the censer with one hand to his chest.

“It is important. I know. But I worry about you. If you should fall—”

The other Soldiers would lose their leader. Yellow Splatters understood at last. That would weaken them, possibly leading to more casualties.

Already, he was able to influence his unit as a whole in small ways, like leading a charge with his Skills and so on. He readjusted his view of his usefulness in combat. He *was* a leader and care was important. Still, Yellow Splatters couldn't fault his actions. Saving a Soldier's life was paramount.

Pawn seemed to agree, because he dropped that line of conversation. He looked to the books again and opened his mandibles, then hesitated.

"I ah—notice you have put yourself on combat duty every day for the last two weeks."

Yellow Splatters nodded. Pawn reached out and touched Yellow Splatter's arms. The blood had stopped, but Yellow Splatters had broken chitin on multiple places on his carapace. Pawn looked distressed.

"It is important to have a [Sergeant], but it is not necessary that you fight every battle, Yellow Splatters. You need rest."

Not yet. The Soldier stood tall, disregarding this suggestion from Pawn. Once he had agonized over everything Pawn said; now he recognized the Worker spoke out of ignorance at times. Misplaced worry and concern for his wellbeing, true, but ignorance all the same. He *had* to fight, to keep fighting. The battle was all that mattered. So long as his people were dying, he had to fight.

If Pawn understood that, he didn't show it. Rather, he looked down at the censer and then up at Yellow Splatters.

"I believe you need rest. Or rather, a different kind of rest in addition to your regular sleep, Yellow Splatters."

Sergeant. Yellow Splatters had no eyes to narrow, but he stared hard at Pawn. What did he mean?

"I am assigning you to tonight's surface patrol, Yellow Splatters."

The Soldier recoiled. A surface patrol? That was...ludicrous. He didn't need to go above!

Above was different from below. Below was real combat, dangerous fighting. Whereas above...Yellow Splatters could remember the joy of first seeing the sun, of walking around and staring at the strange Drakes and Gnolls and people and buildings and...everything! But that enjoyment had become a distant memory. Now he only cared for what really mattered, which was doing his duty.

He wasn't some new Soldier who needed to become Individual. But Pawn clearly disagreed. He rested a hand on Yellow Splatter's arm, speaking softly.

"Some food and different scenery will help, or so I believe. And I would like you to meet the Soldier in charge of leading the patrols aboveground. I am considering making him the next [Sergeant]."

That got Yellow Splatter's attention. He stepped back, letting Pawn's hand fall off his arm. Another [Sergeant]? Yellow Splatters would be only too willing to see another leader to help protect the Soldiers, but who? Of course he shared the barracks with all the Individual Soldiers, but he was not familiar with the one Pawn mentioned. He had not gone aboveground since he had been promoted.

"The Antinium in question is named Purple Smile. I believe he is taking some Soldiers and new Individuals up in a few minutes. Over there."

Pawn pointed, and Yellow Splatters saw a group of Soldiers gathering to go to the surface. Among them was Twin Stripes. Yellow Splatters strode over, cutting the rest of what Pawn was saying off, and saw the Soldier in charge standing by one of the exits to the barracks.

He was a Soldier. And in that, he was like the others. Only, this Soldier struck Yellow Splatters as somewhat odd instantly. He had paint markings

on his body, of course, but instead of putting them on his arms, legs, chest, or back, he'd put them on his face.

In fact, he'd carefully painted a purple ring around both of his insectile eyes, and drawn what looked like a smile across his mandibles and lower face. The effect was, well, horrific if you weren't another Antinium. But it was a smile on his face, and his posture wasn't the military-straightness of most Soldiers either. He leaned against the dirt wall. Since Antinium had problems bending backwards—their carapaces got in the way—he was doing a crazy tilt with his body, leaning his head back against the wall.

It looked ridiculous to Yellow Splatters. However, Purple Smile seemed to be enjoying the activity, and two other Soldiers had already tried to copy him. Yellow Splatters marched over and Purple Smile propelled himself off the wall. He nodded and Yellow Splatters nodded back.

The Soldiers had nothing as elaborate as hand signals. In battle, Yellow Splatters could direct other Soldiers with his mind to a limited degree, which is why pointing is all he needed to do. By contrast Purple Smile pointed, wagged his fingers, and walked them in mimicry of what they were *supposed* to be doing already. He led the way out of the Antinium Hive at a relaxed, *slow* pace.

Yellow Splatters already disliked him. And he could not understand why *this* Soldier of all Soldiers was being considered for a [Sergeant] position!

They went above. Yellow Splatters strode out onto the cobblestone street, not pausing to stare up at the sun or around at the city like all the new Soldiers were doing. Even the ones who'd been above once or twice, like Twin Stripes, were staring.

Purple Smile let them do it. In fact, he kept staring up at a cloud so long that Yellow Splatters had to click his mandibles to get him to move. At last,

the other Soldier led them down the street, towards the western gates and the inn that was their regular starting point for each patrol.

It was a mark of the trust Liscor had in the Antinium that a patrol could now be led by one of the Soldiers and not by Pawn himself. Yellow Splatters marched, staring directly at Purple Smile as he meandered down the street. Of course, non-Antinium still got out of the way for their patrol, but Yellow Splatters appreciated that.

What bothered him was the clear awe the other Soldiers held their surroundings in. Every now and then Purple Smile would let them stop to stare at a passing Drake, or at a brick wall, or—or a patch of melting *snow*!

It hurt to see Soldiers like Twin Stripes, who were pathetically grateful to see the sky, who stared upwards with awe. It hurt because Yellow Splatters understood how mundane the sky was. These other people, the Drakes who passed by on the other side of the street, the Gnolls who sniffed the air and sneezed as they passed by, they saw the sky every day! But most Soldiers would die without this smallest of privileges.

Yellow Splatters snapped his mandibles together irritably and Purple Smile turned to look at him curiously. Pointedly, Yellow Splatters looked ahead and Purple Smile reluctantly picked up the pace.

At last, they marched out of the city and through the wet snow to the inn. There Purple Smile knocked on the door. It was some time before it opened, and when it did, he heard muffled voices and a lot of shuffling sounds.

“Hi, hi! Sorry for the delay!”

The door opened and Erin Solstice opened it, smiling widely. Yellow Splatters stared at her, and saw Purple Smile open and raise his mandibles in a smile. Erin peered at him and then smiled back.

“Hey, it’s you! Scary-purple-smile-guy! How’s it been? You’re here for food, right? Where’s Pawn? Not with you this time? Well, come on in and —”

She opened the door wider and Yellow Splatters froze. Inside the inn were monsters.

Goblins. Five of them, sitting around a table, eating. They froze when they saw the Antinium. One reached for a sword until another grabbed his arm. Yellow Splatters was quicker, though. He raised his fists and the Soldiers around him stared. Belatedly, copying his example, they raised theirs. Erin’s eyes went round and wide.

“Wait, what are you doing?”

The Goblins in the inn reacted to the threat. They surged upwards, pushing their chairs back and now all of them did draw their weapons. Immediately Yellow Splatters and the other Soldiers tensed up, grouping together, getting ready to rush in.

Goblins! Yellow Splatters buzzed with anticipation. So, there was real fighting to be had above, was there? He hadn’t ever met this kind of Goblin before—they were far larger than the pallid, small Goblins who sometimes rushed the tunnels, but he’d take them down anyways. He began to charge when a set of four hands grabbed him.

Purple Smile yanked Yellow Splatters back and barred the way into the inn. He pointed at the Goblins and shook his head, to the surprise of all the Soldiers. Meanwhile, Erin was yelping, waving her hands and saying the same thing.

“Don’t attack! They’re friendly! I thought Pawn told you—these are good Goblins, okay? There’s no need to fight! Does *anyone* read the sign?”

Erin looked exasperatedly towards Purple Smile. He raised an authoritative hand and Yellow Splatters realized that Pawn had said something of the kind, only he'd walked away too fast to hear. Slowly, reluctantly, he lowered his fists and the other Soldiers copied him.

“That’s the first time I’ve had to—who’s the big guy? Wait, we’ve met, haven’t we?”

The [Innkeeper] stared at Yellow Splatters curiously. He returned the look for a second and then glanced at Purple Smile. The Goblins sat down cautiously and Purple Smile walked into the room as if nothing was the matter. Warily, Yellow Splatters followed.

The other Soldiers entered the inn, sitting at a group of tables far away from the Goblins, staring at them curiously. Those who’d been to the inn before were clearly eager for food. Yellow Splatters sat in a seat with a good view of the Goblins—just in case—and focused his attention on the young woman rushing in and out of the kitchen, calling for help.

“Sorry, sorry! I was feeding Mrsha—oh! The Antinium are here! I’ll be right with you all with your orders!”

Lyonette rushed downstairs, smiling as soon as she saw the Antinium. She seemed to know Purple Smile too, and waved to him as she hurried into the kitchen. Yellow Splatters continued staring at Erin every time she came out.

He couldn’t understand why Pawn held Erin in such high regard. He had taken Yellow Splatters to see Erin, and told him about how he had become Individual thanks to her. And yes, Yellow Splatters acknowledged she was willing to cook for the Antinium and had taught Pawn to play chess. What of it? Could she help save Soldiers’ lives?

Her soup could. But the food that was placed in front of the Antinium wasn’t the enchanted mixture they sometimes ate before battle. Rather, it

was a scramble of eggs, bacon, and cheese, a hot bowl of filling food. It was ideal since Antinium couldn't handle gluten. And it was also useless.

Useless. Yellow Splatters felt his innards gurgling as he stared at the food and inhaled its aroma. He wanted to eat it, and yet something stayed his hand. Purple Smile was already munching down his food with gusto, as were the rest of the Soldiers, but the longer Yellow Splatters stared at his bowl, the angrier he got.

It was hard to explain. Yes, the food smelled wonderful. However, Yellow Splatters couldn't focus on it. His thoughts were below, with the Soldiers whom Belgrade had assigned to the dungeon's entrance. How could he eat while they were suffering? There were Soldiers dying in the Hive *right now*. Soldiers who would never taste this food. And here he was being served this—while his people might never have such luxuries!

Yellow Splatters didn't know what he was doing until he was on his feet. Erin had paused as she was coming out with hot honey milk for all the Soldiers. Yellow Splatters lifted his bowl. Deliberately, staring at her the entire time, he overturned it, letting the hot food fall to the floor.

Erin blinked. The Soldiers sitting around Yellow Splatters froze. He folded both sets of arms, looking around challengingly. The Goblins had paused in eating and they were poking each other and staring at him, muttering. But Yellow Splatters didn't care about that.

He looked at the other Soldiers. *They* were free to eat if they wished, but Yellow Splatters wouldn't waste the Hive's resources purchasing food when there were more important things to do. He received enough nutrition from the food in the Hive. This patrol aboveground, paying for food, eating with monsters—it was all pointless!

The other Soldiers stared at him, and then at Purple Smile. The Soldier had paused when Yellow Splatter overturned his bowl. He looked at the

splatter of food on the ground and bent. He scooped up the fallen eggs and cheese and bacon and slopped a handful into his bowl.

“Oh don’t do that—I can make more. If you don’t like it, I can uh—what’s the matter?”

Erin raised her hands, looking uncertainly at Yellow Splatters. But then the other Soldiers moved. As one, all except for Purple Smile, they pushed back their bowls and stood up. Yellow Splatters saw Twin Stripes hesitate before pushing back his bowl of eggs, untouched.

“What?”

Erin stared around, and Lyonette poked her head out of the kitchen, disbelieving. Purple Smile stared around in silence, and then clicked his mandibles together softly and got up without a word. Yellow Splatters looked around the inn, at Erin, at the Goblins, and then turned.

The Antinium left the inn as one. They marched quickly back into the city and into the Hive. Once there, they began to train. Or rather, Yellow Splatters did and the others followed his example. Yellow Splatters worked his arms and legs, trading blows, pushing himself harder. Pawn wasn’t there—probably thinking he’d be out of the city for several hours.

Yellow Splatters didn’t mind the patrol with Purple Smile after an hour of sparring and then eating brown paste at one of the mess halls. He felt good about the entire affair, actually. He had established what *should* be done and the other Soldiers had followed his example. Hopefully, now they’d stop going above altogether and they could focus on what was really important.

Fighting. Fighting in order to save lives. Compared to that, eating, seeing the sky...it was all pointless.

“You did *what*?”

It was perhaps the first time Pawn had ever raised his voice when speaking to a Soldier. He stood in front of Yellow Splatters, his mandibles opened wide and lowered in disbelief. Yellow Splatters looked ahead, waiting for Pawn to finish talking.

“The patrol is what Soldiers look forward to each day! The food was already paid for—why waste it?”

Yellow Splatters didn’t bother trying to explain to Pawn. He was a Worker. That was becoming more obvious. He glanced towards the pile of unread books and then away. Yellow Splatters turned.

“Sergeant! I am not done speaking with you—”

But he was done listening. The Soldier marched back to the sparring area and raised his four fists. The other Soldiers stared at him uncertainly, looking back towards Pawn. Yellow Splatters ignored them and gestured.

They’d have to expand the fighting area soon. It was too confined to allow more than a fifth of the barracks to practice at once. Too, they needed a larger barracks. More Soldiers should become Individual. Yes, a lot more. Pawn could take *them* on patrols to the surface rather than waste time here.

Yellow Splatters looked around for a partner since none were coming to him. He spotted a familiar Soldier, punching weakly with another one in a corner of the sparring area. Twin Stripes wavered as Yellow Splatters approached, but he put his fists up and tried to spar.

This time Yellow Splatters made Twin Stripes go on the offensive, blocking blows, thrusting aside weak punches. He put force behind his

blocks, making Twin Stripes work hard for every hit he landed. He kept the spar going until someone thrust himself between the two Soldiers.

Pawn again. The Worker pushed Twin Stripes back since Yellow Splatters wouldn't move. He clicked his mandibles together repeatedly, looking angrily at the [Sergeant].

“Enough. He is exhausted.”

The Soldier looked towards Twin Stripes. Yes, he was wavering on his feet. So what? That was the *point*. Soldiers had to fight when they were tired. Sparring like this was the only way to level up, to become stronger. He tried to push past Pawn, but the Worker barred his way.

“I said, enough! I am your leader—I order you to stop, Yellow Splatters!”

Yellow Splatters stared at Pawn. Then he carefully put one of his spade-like hands out and pushed the Worker out of the way.

The barracks, never loud to begin with, went completely silent. Every Soldier stared at Yellow Splatters and at Pawn, frozen where they stood. They stared at Pawn. The Worker seemed as stunned as the others. He looked to Yellow Splatters. The Soldier turned his back on the Worker and raised his fists.

Every Soldier in the room stared at their [Sergeant], and then at Pawn. They hesitated. They looked back and forth, and then, silently, chose. They turned their backs on Pawn, looking to Yellow Splatters instead. He smiled, and turned to Twin Stripes. The other Soldier was looking at Pawn, but he jerked back towards Yellow Splatters. He too raised his fists and Yellow Splatters beckoned. He lashed out and Twin Stripes dodged back wearily.

Helplessly, Pawn stood, watching the other Soldiers. Now they were all sparring, all carefully not looking at him. He looked around, but none of the

other Antinium would meet his gaze. Guiltily, they looked away and followed their leader, Yellow Splatters. He smiled as he continued to spar.

Yes, this was how it should be. Pawn was a...Worker in the end. He had his role, but that was only to assist the Soldiers. They were doing the important job. Fight, train, and die. Fight to make sure the other Soldiers would live longer.

Wasn't that all that mattered? Yellow Splatters looked into Twin Stripe's multifaceted eyes and saw his reflection looking back. Yes. It was the only thing that mattered.

The inn had never been so quiet, never been as empty as these last few days. Lyonette sat at one of the tables, cleaning up bowls of food, barely touched. She poured some lukewarm eggs from one bowl into another and paused.

"It's so *much*. We can't waste this, can we?"

"Dunno."

Drassi shrugged, looking concerned. She had arrived a few minutes ago to help with what should have been the evening rush. Instead, she was helping clean up from the Antinium after they had left abruptly. Lyonette had *no* idea what had happened there, only that it had something to do with that strange Antinium with the yellow splashes on his body.

"I know the Antinium have eaten some of it, but it seems a shame to waste. Couldn't we...feed it to someone? Give it away somehow? I mean..."

She didn't really want to eat food the Antinium had been nibbling on, but it did feel like a shame. Drassi paused and eyed the table.

"What if we scooped it all up and found some pigs to give it to? There's at least one [Farmer] around here who keeps pigs. Or goats. We could give it to them. I know this old Drake who raises these huge pigs that taste really great—I could ask him if you want. I don't think the pigs will mind the bacon, I mean, they eat everything and I mean *everything*."

"That's a good idea, Drassi!"

Lyonette smiled. The talkative Drake [Barmaid] grinned at her and emptied another bowl into a larger container. Then she froze and her scales turned pale as she looked up. Lyonette turned her head and froze.

A Goblin stood in front of their table. He was just standing there, but the Hobgoblin was taller than either Drake or Human, and both their eyes were drawn to the sword hanging at his belt. He was wearing pants and a belt—awkwardly—but that didn't disguise his Goblin features, only emphasize them.

"Uh—uh—"

Drassi trembled and took a step back. Lyonette made herself stand taller and smile at the Hobgoblin, although her heart was pounding.

"Hi there. Headscratcher, isn't it? Can I help you?"

The Goblin nodded. Gingerly, Headscratcher pointed to the bowls of eggs and mimed eating them. Lyonette blinked.

"What, you want them? Don't you mind that they've been eaten?"

Headscratcher shook his head. Lyonette traded glances with Drassi.

"Okay then—uh, let us bring them over."

She waited until Headscratcher retreated to the table where the five Goblins were sitting. They were already eating a pile of greasy bacon—and several loaves of buttered bread, but Lyonette knew their appetites were endless. She turned to Drassi and the Drake gave her a pleading look.

“Lyonette, I—”

“You just collect the bowls here, and I’ll bring them over, okay?”

The Drake gave her a pathetic look of gratitude. Lyonette hurried over to the table. The Goblins cleared a space and the one called Badarrow grunted in what might have been thanks. He was definitely the grumpy Goblin of the five. Not that Lyonette had gotten to know them that well; they kept to themselves.

They kept eating, and Lyonette finished putting the last bowl on their table. She retreated to finish cleaning up with Drassi. Both [Barmaids] got out rags and soapy water and began to scrub, chattering amongst themselves.

“That scared me. I mean, I’ve been here two days with them and I know they’re...okay. But I just come in and—”

“I know.”

Lyonette sighed as she looked back towards the Goblins. She caught one of them—Numbtongue—looking at her and both Goblin and Human quickly glanced away. Lyonette grimaced.

The Goblins. Of all Erin’s ideas, and she had had many good ones, crazy ones, and extraordinarily bad ones, this might be the worst. Not that Lyonette didn’t have sympathy or understand why she’d done it. It was just that the consequence of her actions had really sunk in by now.

The inn was deserted. No one had come in today, from Celum or Liscor save for the two adventuring groups staying here. Added to that, the one

employee who came by—Ishkr still hadn't returned after Brunkr's death—was scared stiff of the Goblins. If it came to that, so was Lyonette.

How could she not be? They were Goblins, no, not just Goblins, but *Hobgoblins*, the terror of little childrens' dreams! You heard stories of Hobs sneaking into houses to kidnap children, and the way they could kill Silver-rank adventurers. It was all very well for them to sit around and just eat, but every time Lyonette saw their crimson eyes or caught them staring at her, she felt afraid.

And she never knew what they were thinking, either. The Goblins rarely spoke, just poked each other and grunted. And if they *did* speak, it was in their own guttural language. She couldn't tell if they hated her, if they liked what was going on, or anything. Whenever they came out of the cellar Lyonette felt like she was walking on eggshells.

Drassi clearly felt the same way. She was chattering, as usual. And whenever Drassi was upset, she chattered *more* than usual. Lyonette had gotten used to it and tried to tune most of it out.

"It's just, I mean, I'm cool with Gnolls. Grew up around them my whole life, dated two—not that fun, let me tell you. Gnolls get so *serious* when you're in a relationship, talking about the tribe, never wanting to just have a fling—and they're furry. Hair everywhere, especially in beds. Scales I can handle, but hair? I don't know how you Humans stand it. But then, you don't have much hair, do you? But Gnolls...and the Antinium are fine. I don't see them much. Klbkch has been around ever since I was young, so I'm totally used to him—"

"Mhm."

"And Humans? Hah, *totally* cool. Okay, every year there are drills and alarms when the Humans send an army to the Bloodfields and we're not supposed to like them and ancient history and all that but, Ancestors, at

least they're fun to party with! That door to Celum is great—and the plays! I liked them, I really did, although a bunch of my friends hated the Juliet and Romeo one. You know, because of interspecies relationships? I dunno, *I* don't mind, do you?"

"Yeah."

"Exactly! So Goblins. Totally get what Erin's saying. I think. No killing Goblins. They don't kill us, we don't kill them. Easy. Except for the Goblin Lord. And Goblins who steal. That's a problem. But I wish they'd talk, you know? Raise their voices? It'd be better than scaring my scales off—I might go bald! At my age! If they just said something—"

Too late, Lyonette realized where Drassi was going and saw a Goblin moving. One stood up from his table and Drassi shut up quick. She backed up and Lyonette stepped in front of her. The Goblin who was walking towards them was...Numbtongue. She smiled at him, remembering where Erin had told her all of Octavia's alchemy weapons were hidden.

"Hi, sorry about that. Drassi was just talking."

"Hm."

He narrowed his eyes at her. Lyonette could feel Drassi shaking. She smiled, and then, amazingly, Numbtongue grunted and *spoke*.

"No offense. Clarify. To Drake. Why Goblins not speak."

She gaped at him. Behind him, Drassi had frozen.

"You can *speak*?"

Numbtongue gave her an exasperated look and nodded. The other four Goblins were leaning out from their table, peering at his back. They looked away as Lyonette's eyes slid towards them. Numbtongue grumbled a bit, and then looked at Drassi. He narrowed his eyes at her and spoke again.

“Goblins can speak. Speak all kinds of word. And can hear. Can *listen*. Don’t speak because we don’t need. Understand?”

The Drake quivered and nodded repeatedly.

“Y-yes! I totally understand! You’re good? That’s good! I’m glad everyone’s good! Please don’t get mad! I was only—”

Drassi shrank back against the wall, serving platter clutched in front of her like a shield. Numbtongue looked at her, snorted, and then stomped away. Lyonette wavered between going after him and comforting Drassi. She chose the latter.

“Don’t worry! He was just trying to—to well, explain, I guess. Goblins can speak, they just don’t want to. And they can hear us, okay?”

“Got it! Got it. I was just—I was talking and I didn’t mean—”

“I’m sure they’re not offended.”

Lyonette peeked at the Goblins. Badarrow rolled his eyes and shook his head. Shorthilt looked up, halfway through inhaling a rash of bacon, and waved a hand. Drassi relaxed a bit.

“Okay.”

“But why don’t we talk about something else instead? Or not talk?”

“I can do that, I think. Not talk. I did that for an entire day once, on a dare. Selys bet me two silver coins I couldn’t do it, and it was worth it seeing her face. And I don’t talk *all* the time, I just like to talk, you know? Who doesn’t talk to people? It’s better to talk than not talk is what I say, which is why I thought about being a [Receptionist], but Selys said that if I applied she’d quit, so I decided—”

Smiling, Lyonette rolled her eyes and turned around. She frowned as she saw a flash of white by the stairs.

“Mrsha?”

Every head downstairs turned. The Gnoll cub froze as she crept downstairs, the wand she’d stolen from Pisces in hand. Her eyes went wide as she saw the Goblins looking at her. She looked to Lyonette.

“It’s okay. They’re just eating. Sorry—”

Lyonette looked at the Goblins and they turned back to their food. Erin had explained to the Goblins that Mrsha was afraid of them, although Erin hadn’t brought up the details of Goblins actually slaughtering her tribe. Lyonette approached the stairwell, holding her hands out. Mrsha was trembling as she stared at the Goblins’ backs.

“Mrsha, honey—”

The Gnoll looked at her, made a hissing sound, and fled back upstairs. Lyonette nearly went after them, until she heard Erin’s voice.

“Okay, I am *done* making bread! I’ve made enough bread for an entire month, so if we need it—bread’s done! Whew!”

She emerged from the kitchen in a small cloud of flour, dusting her hands. Erin had been cooking a lot in order to keep up with the Goblins’ appetites. She spotted the Goblins and walked over to them, smiling carefully.

“Heeeeeey.”

They looked up at her warily. Erin paused a few feet from their table and raised her voice. She was trying a bit too hard to be friendly, Lyonette thought.

“How are you guys doing? Good? Sorry about the Antinium. Don’t know what was up with that. You liking the food?”

They nodded. Erin stared at them.

“How’s the bacon? Good? Anyone want more?”

They nodded, and then shook their heads. Lyonette stared at Numbtongue, but he didn’t seem inclined to say anything. Erin hesitated. Clearly she would have preferred conversation.

“You’re cool? I mean, you don’t want more food?”

The Goblins nodded. Erin stared helplessly at them.

“Okay, then. Let me know if you need...anything.”

They did not. And when they were done eating, they got up, went to use the outhouse, and then opened the cellar door and went into the basement without a word. Lyonette collected the bowls and utensils. They’d been licked clean.

“I guess you can wash these if you want.”

She suggested that to Drassi. The Drake nodded, and then looked anxious.

“Lyonette, look...I haven’t been doing much, and there’s not a lot for me to do right now. Are you sure I should be here? I can work less time if you think—”

Lyonette forced herself to smile at Drassi reassuringly.

“What, and rob you of your pay? Don’t worry about it. Erin tells me we have a lot of money, and *I* don’t want to wash all these dishes.”

“Still, wiping a few tables and washing dishes isn’t exactly a lot, you know?”

She had a point. Lyonette thought and replied carefully.

“If you want to take care of the Horns of Hammerad and Halfseekers when they come by, I could use a break. How about that?”

Drassi beamed in relief.

“Oh, yes, thanks! I can’t just go back and not do anything; I’d feel like a total sponge, just like Wessa! Have I told you about her? *Dreadful*. She’s got no class—or classes! I think she’s, what, a Level 2 [Laborer]? She sponges money off of everyone. Now, I try to talk to her, but she never listens. Do you know what she told Selys one time? Selys nearly decked her for saying it. Okay it was—”

Lyonette listened to her for a few more minutes, nodding mechanically, and then excused herself to go into the kitchen while Drassi wiped the Goblins’ table down. Erin was sitting in the kitchen, in front of about forty loaves of pristine bread. Lyonette stared at the bread pile and then looked at Erin.

“Everything...okay, Erin?”

“Yes. No.”

Erin stared at the bread she’d baked all day, looking glum. She turned towards Lyonette.

“No. It’s the Goblins.”

“What...precisely about them?”

The [Innkeeper] sighed.

“I don’t know if they like it here, Lyonette. I don’t know if I’m talking with them or if it’s all pointless, you know?”

“I think I do.”

Erin nodded, ticking off problems on her floury fingers.

“They don’t like chess, other games, talking, or hanging around upstairs, Lyonette. I guess I can’t blame them, since no one likes them. And no one

will come here until they're gone, which I know might not be a bad thing, but if they go now—"

"You want to be friends with them first?"

Lyonette rested her backside on the counter. Erin looked at her, shrugged, tried to laugh, and gave up.

"Not that. I don't need to be friends with them, but I want them to understand me. I want to understand *them*, just a bit. Or—or I want them to leave and know how I feel about them. I'm just trying to tell them—I don't know."

Erin sighed, her shoulders slumping. She looked at Lyonette, worry in her eyes.

"If they disappear in the middle of the night, Lyonette, or decide to try and find Rags or—or do anything, I think they'll be killed. Zevara's watching the inn—I can feel it. And I'm not sure the Halfseekers wouldn't follow them either. And if they got around all of them, if they go back north—the Goblin Lord's soldiers will kill them, right? They're the enemy tribe."

"Maybe. But they're used to living alone, aren't they? Don't you think they'd prefer to find their own people?"

Carefully, Lyonette peeked at Erin. The young woman sighed.

"Probably. It's just that I don't think they know where Rags is. And... they're lost, Lyonette. Lost. That's what I get from them. I want to help them a bit. And I just don't know if I can, or if they're willing. I can't understand them."

"I think they understand more than they let on."

"Yeah. Probably. But even if they do, that's not the same as connecting with us, as liking us or—or getting to really know us."

“Mm. Maybe they don’t want to. Have you thought about that?”

Erin looked up. Her gaze firmed a bit as she met Lyonette’s eyes.

“I have. And I don’t believe that. Rags wanted to know. I think these Goblins are just—afraid.”

Afraid? Only Erin would characterize them that way. Lyonette sat with her, not knowing what else to say.

“They’ll have to do something sometime. They’re already starting to eat less.”

“Yeah. I think it’ll end soon, one way or the other. Thanks for putting up with this, Lyonette. I know Mrsha’s...”

“Yes.”

Mrsha. She refused to eat downstairs anymore, and she had grown increasingly agitated as days went by. She refused to play with Lyonette, refused to give back Pisces’ wand—not that he’d tried hard to recover it—and Lyonette knew she was growing more upset. She might have tried to get Selys or Krshia to look after her, but Mrsha refused to go. She refused to leave and she refused to go anywhere near the Goblins.

Both girls were silent for a moment, and then Erin looked up.

“Thank you for all the help, Lyonette. Can you bear with it for a while longer? I think it won’t be long.”

“I can, don’t worry about me.”

“Thank you.”

Lyonette smiled. And she was telling the truth. But as she left Erin to sit by herself in the kitchen, she thought that she wasn’t the one Erin needed to be worried about. The inn had been empty for days, Drassi was afraid,

Mrsha wouldn't go downstairs or interact with Lyonette, and the Goblins were growing restless.

The Horns of Hammerad and Halfseekers barely came back except to eat and sleep, and sometimes not to eat. And the Antinium had been acting *very* odd lately. Especially the one who'd refused to eat his food. If they all started refusing to eat at Erin's inn, how long could it stay open with almost no revenue?

Yes, she wasn't the one Erin should be worried about. It was everyone else.

Night fell. But that didn't mean there wasn't work to do. Yellow Splatters knew the dungeon sent monsters to attack, be it day or night, so he took the first rotation on the front lines. They had been pushed up right to the dungeon's entrance, so he took nineteen Soldiers, including Twin Stripes, to be on alert.

They clashed with monsters twice, both times smashing the enemy—a wave of Shield Spiders and then giant centipedes—into pulp. Yellow Splatters kept the Soldiers at their post for four hours, and then brought them back to the barracks.

He was tired now, but he still had enough energy, so Yellow Splatters began to spar with the Soldiers on the night rotation. Train, *train!* He wanted to get to Level 13 today or tomorrow. He was so engrossed in his mock combat with the two Soldiers that he only noticed Twin Stripes when he walked into the sparring arena.

The new Antinium Soldier was battered from his day's activities. The cracked chitin from Yellow Splatters' blows, the fatigue of going above and

then patrolling with the other Soldiers—he was clearly tired, but Yellow Splatters appreciated his willingness to spar. He stepped towards Twin Stripes, ready for a bout, when the other Antinium began to suddenly shudder.

Yellow Splatters stopped in surprise. Twin Stripes was trembling in place, in the center of the sparring area. He was shaking, bending to clutch at his antennae, backing up from Yellow Splatters. His mandibles clashed together wildly, and then his body convulsed.

His head lowered, and then it rose. All four of Twin Stripe's hands clenched into fists, and as he looked up, towards Yellow Splatters, there was something different about his gaze. His mandibles opened as wide as they could, and a strangled, half-scream emerged from his mouth.

The Soldiers in the barracks froze. Soldiers didn't *speak*! They couldn't make real noises, but Twin Stripes—

There was madness in his gaze. No, not madness. Something worse. He trembled as he lurched towards Yellow Splatters, and the [Sergeant] Antinium realized with a cold chill what had happened.

Aberration. Twin Stripes had become an Aberration.

But how? He was Individual! He shouldn't become—Soldiers almost never became—

It was too late for questions. Twin Stripes lunged at Yellow Splatters, hands reaching to tear him apart. He bit, his mandibles trying to pierce Yellow Splatters' body, his fists pounding on the larger Antinium.

Other Soldiers rushed forwards, yanking Twin Stripes off Yellow Splatters. There were over a hundred in the barracks, but Twin Stripes fought with possessed strength, throwing Soldiers off him, battering the

ones who tried to hold him down, all the while trying to attack Yellow Splatters.

In the end, Twin Stripes was contained, bars of iron bent and hammered into crude restraints to prevent him from attacking anyone. He still thrashed around on the ground though, staring at Yellow Splatters. With...hate in his eyes.

It was incomprehensible. Yellow Splatters lay where he had fallen, even when Pawn and Klbkch rushed into the barracks, demanding answers. He stared at Twin Stripes, as the Aberration gazed in fury at him and was taken to a holding cell. A holding cell that had to be constructed before he could be taken there.

Yellow Splatters lay on the ground, seeing Soldiers look at him, avoiding Pawn's despairing gaze and sensing Purple Smile staring at him across the room. But all the while, he was looking at Twin Stripes, at the Soldier who had abandoned who he was. Why? For what reason? They were doing this *for* Soldiers like Twin Stripes. Everything Yellow Splatters had done—the war was still continuing. Why had Twin Stripes become Aberration?

He did not understand.

Miles from where Yellow Splatters lay, far higher and aboveground, a young Gnoll was awake. Mrsha had not slept, though Lyonette was already wrapped up in her blankets in the room the two shared. No, Mrsha had been awake. Her nose twitched as she padded past Lyonette's head, tail tucked

between her legs. How could she sleep when there were monsters, killers, *murderers* in the same building?

She crept around in her room, her nose full of the smells of the Goblins slumbering below. She could smell them throughout the inn now, no matter how much she buried her face in the comforting smells of Lyonette's pillow or opened the windows to let the cold air in.

Killers. Tribe murderers. Monsters. Mrsha could remember them streaming through the snow, cutting down her friends, family. The Stone Spears tribe, everyone—

Urksh.

The memories tore at Mrsha. Mrsha, the [Lone Survivor]. That knowledge weighed on her hardest of all. She sniffed, and knew the Goblins were sleeping. They were right below her, *right below*.

She prowled, and her teeth ground together as her claws clicked across the floor. The wand she'd stolen from Pisces was grasped awkwardly in her paw. Mrsha swung it again, but it didn't do any magic.

They were here. And they would be in the inn, eating, *laughing*, living, while her tribe was dead. Not right. It was *not right*. Mrsha growled, and Lyonette stirred. The Gnoll quieted, but the feeling remained in the silence. She sat up as the night grew longer, her paw gripping the wand tightly, smelling the Goblins.

Hating, hating, *hating*.

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Yellow Splatters woke up a few hours after dawn for his shift. He got up, ate the pinkish-brown paste he was served, and marched at the head of his unit of Soldiers to the front. Pawn was not there. Neither was Twin Stripes.

It felt *wrong*. And yet, this *is* what Yellow Splatters had wanted, wasn't it? The thought threw the [Sergeant] as he set a quick pace down the tunnels. Yes. No. It was...different from what he'd wanted.

He hadn't wanted Twin Stripes to become an Aberration, obviously. That was simply an anomaly, something Yellow Splatters couldn't explain. Weakness, perhaps. As for Pawn, he just wanted the Worker to know his place. And that place was *helping* Soldiers, not—not running off!

“Ah. Yellow Splatters. You're here.”

The Soldier stopped and the thirty Soldiers he'd brought paused behind him. Anand, Belgrade, and Pawn were all standing around the command 'table', which was really just a folding table made of wood they could put a map on. Pawn met Yellow Splatters' eyes as the Soldier approached, but said nothing. Yellow Splatters did his best to pretend he didn't exist.

If Anand was aware of the situation, he didn't show it. The [Tactician] was rapidly giving out orders to Soldiers and Workers around him. The dungeon's attacks weren't exactly like clockwork—not that the Antinium were familiar with that concept anyways—but they could be predicted with a good deal of accuracy. And right now it was about to get dangerous.

“I'm already receiving reports of movement around two of the dungeon entrances. I want to be ready when they hit. Yellow Splatters, divide your command into three equal groups for today. I will be using them to strike

targets of opportunity while you engage the most dangerous foes that appear.”

Yellow Splatters snapped to attention and turned. He gestured, and the Soldiers moved with mechanical precision. Gone was his indecisiveness of earlier, his worries. *This* was what he was made to do. War. It was so simple.

Anand nodded in approval and immediately sent Yellow Splatters towards the nearest signs of monster activity. The other two groups were assigned to Pawn and a Soldier as Yellow Splatters left. He didn’t like Pawn being in charge, but there was no time to dwell on it.

The monsters were coming.

Trivipers, a group of armed Raskghar and Cave Goblins, a small horde of Shield Spiders, and worst of all, a Bagrhaven. The monsters seemed unusually agitated today, or perhaps there were just more of them than usual. Yellow Splatters didn’t care. His group of ten Painted Soldiers smashed into each new threat, sometimes accompanied by other Soldiers, sometimes not.

It didn’t matter. They won each time. Yellow Splatters fought as hard as he could, relishing the simple brutality of it. He didn’t have to think when he was in combat. Actually, he did—but it wasn’t about difficult things.

Like Twin Stripes. Or Pawn. Yellow Splatters couldn’t get his mind off them, no matter how hard he tried. It wasn’t his fault that Twin Stripes had become an Aberration! No. No, it wasn’t. Twin Stripes had...done something wrong. Or maybe he was wrong from the start. But Yellow

Splatters had shown him what to do, what was *right* and he'd become an Aberration on his own. That was all there was to it.

The Soldiers under Yellow Splatters' command retreated after slaying the Bagrhaven, their carapaces damaged by her long claws. Personally, Yellow Splatters thought they could fight longer, but Anand had given them the order to pull back.

The [Tactician] was leading the fighting around all three dungeon entrances today. Belgrade was giving no orders, which both puzzled and relieved Yellow Splatters. He would have been happy if the Workers had left everything to Anand, but distressingly, they were *still* holding the ground around all three entrances, far closer to the dungeon than made sense. Anand's mobile strategy was far more difficult to employ in the few tunnels they were holding.

The [Sergeant] marched his unit back behind the lines of Soldiers and Workers flooding ahead to hold the breach and clear away monster and Antinium bodies, thinking hard. Was it because Anand was worried monsters might slip through into the rest of the Hive? Or was it Belgrade's stupid ideas taking hold in him as well? He wasn't sure, but he was angry. And he got angrier when he saw the stone.

In the tunnels where his unit had been pulled back to rest in was a sea of Workers, far more than usual for the front. Workers were poor combatants compared to Soldiers and usually only repaired tunnels or hauled away dead bodies. But these were here for a different reason. They were hauling blocks and chunks of stone towards the dirt tunnels, deconstructing walls, opening the area up. Yellow Splatters stared in disbelief.

What were they *doing*? They were removing the tunnels he normally fought in with his Soldiers—the area in which monsters would begin to attack each other if given the chance. And worse, they were using stones! Stones? Who used stones?

In the Hive, construction began and ended with dirt for the most part. The Antinium could pack dirt tightly together and create support beams out of the stuff. Only rarely did they need to use wood, and stone they left alone unless they had to dig through it. It was too cumbersome to use and unnecessary since a group of Workers could excavate a tunnel or rebuild one in less than an hour.

But for some reason, stone had been ordered and here it was. And of course, one [Tactician] was supervising it all. Belgrade was overseeing whatever construction was going on here. Yellow Splatters stared at him with distrust and suspicion until he was ordered back to the front.

This time it was to stop a group of Crypt Lords that were rampaging forwards with a small army of zombies. It was a huge push, and Yellow Splatters arrived at a run to find that one group of the Colored Antinium was already fighting the undead with every Soldier and Worker in the area.

Purple Smile led a group of ten Painted Soldiers, smashing zombies down and stomping the corpses to bits. Yellow Splatters froze when he saw the other Antinium. Anand had put *him* in charge of the other soldiers? His soldiers? Why?

But there was no time to wonder. A Crypt Lord charged into a group of regular Soldiers, a gaping mouth spewing black poisonous blood everywhere. Yellow Splatters ran at the hulking monster and began tearing it apart with his Soldiers.

Advance, tear, punch, rend. Rip. The way Yellow Splatters fought was simple. He trusted to his [Tough Carapace] Skill and used his other abilities to inflict as much damage as possible. The Crypt Lord went down after knocking one of the Painted Soldiers into a wall and spitting black blood over the second.

Yellow Splatters immediately sent the Painted Soldier running back towards the command area for an antidote potion and turned to see how Purple Smile was doing. He *was* a Soldier, after all. That meant he had to be good at fighting, right?

To his outrage, Yellow Splatters saw that across the wide tunnel, Purple Smile was *running away*. The Colored Antinium had all of his Soldiers in full retreat as two Crypt Lords lurched towards them. Why was he running? They had to hold this place! Yellow Splatters ran forwards as the Antinium withdrew. He only froze when he heard a voice shouting at him.

“Sergeant! Hold!”

It was Anand’s voice. The [Tactician] had come to the front himself. The Antinium had fallen back as the Crypt Lords moved further into the tunnel. The zombies were nearly all destroyed, and as Yellow Splatters watched, he saw Purple Smile and his Soldiers moving around the Crypt Lords, flanking them from behind. Anand raised his hand and bellowed an order.

“*Charge!* [Decisive Blows]! [Evasive Tactics]!”

The two Skills immediately took effect and Yellow Splatters charged into the first Crypt Lord. Every time he swung into the rotting undead’s flesh he felt like he was punching as hard as he could. And when the giant monster swiped at him, Yellow Splatters and the Antinium around him were forewarned and already moving out of the way.

The battle ended with both undead torn to pieces. Not a single Soldier or Worker had been hurt or even wounded. Yellow Splatters looked at Anand with appreciation. *This* was real tactics! The Worker nodded at him and pointed back down the tunnel.

“Pull back your Soldiers for now, Yellow Splatters. I think the worst of it is over. We will discuss the after-battle reports with Belgrade and Pawn.”

Yellow Splatters nodded and raised a hand. All twenty Soldiers in the tunnels fell in behind him. He felt proud, tired, but exhilarated with the combat. This was *right!* And none of his Soldiers had fallen in battle today. That proved he was doing the correct thing! His satisfaction lasted all of two seconds, until Anand turned to Purple Smile.

“Good work, Purple Smile. Your tactical decisions were most astute.”

The other Soldier nodded as Anand turned. Yellow Splatters turned to stare at him. His heart began to beat faster and his mandibles snapped together angrily. Purple Smile had done a good job?

What?

“Work is proceeding smoothly. Today should be the end of it, unless I run into an unexpected situation.”

Belgrade was addressing the other two Workers at the table while Yellow Splatters stood at attention, fuming. Partly because he was being ignored, and partly because he had company. Purple Smile stood more or less at attention; he was slouching and rubbing at a cut in his carapace with one hand. Yellow Splatters stared at him and clicked his mandibles together sharply and quickly until Purple Smile reluctantly straightened.

The other three Workers always discussed casualties, unexpected monsters, and so on after each attack when they were together. It was sensible, but today Yellow Splatters didn’t want to be here, especially since no one would ask him his opinion. He was impatient and determined not to show it. Anand nodded to Belgrade as the first [Tactician] bent over the map.

“In that case, we will plan for the worst and assume another day of fighting. We are certainly able to keep the containment for another day at least. Casualties were higher, again, than usual, but thanks to the Colored Antinium we were never in any danger of being overrun.”

“Is that so?”

Pawn glanced at Yellow Splatters as the Soldier stood straighter. Anand nodded, glancing over to him. Then he looked at Purple Smile and lifted his mandibles.

“Yes. Actually, I was delighted to see how Purple Smile reacted today when the Crypt Lords attacked. Your group was efficient, Pawn, and Yellow Splatters subdued more threats than any other, but Purple Smile retreated when the Crypt Lords first attacked, choosing only to fight zombies and buying time for me to send reinforcements. Indeed, his defensive strategy may have saved more lives than if he’d attacked blindly.”

It felt as though Anand had taken a stick and jabbed Yellow Splatters in the insides. He stared at Purple Smile as the other Soldier lifted his own mandibles and waved with two hands at the Workers. Anand bowed slightly towards him, and Belgrade looked approving as well.

“That is fortunate. Indeed. No wonder you suggested he become a [Sergeant] as well, Pawn. I have witnessed Purple Smile’s efficiency in combat as well. He is not as powerful as Yellow Splatters, of course, but his lateral thinking is very impressive. If I may compare it to chess...when I command Yellow Splatters I am reminded of a Rook. Direct, powerful, but limited in that sense. Whereas Purple Smile might be more like a Knight. Less useful in all situations, but able to maneuver around the enemy in many useful ways. In many ways, he fights like you, Anand.”

That last remark threw the [Sergeant] terribly. He had been getting angrier and angrier at Belgrade’s praise, until he’d heard that. Purple Smile?

Like Anand?

Inconceivable. And yet—a part of Yellow Splatters pointed out that pulling back to strike a decisive blow later was a classic move Anand liked to use. Was he really as good as a [Tactician]? Purple Smile?

Yellow Splatters turned to look at the other Soldier. Purple Smile was trying to wipe a bit of liquid off his carapace with his hands. He didn't even appear to be listening! Yellow Splatters' mandibles ground together angrily.

No, he wasn't like Anand at all. It was...different. Yes, it wasn't right because Purple Smile was neither a [Sergeant] nor a [Tactician]! What right did he have to give orders like that, or make decisions on his own?

“Yes, it is useful to have different types of units at your disposal. Our Hive is sadly uniform, so it is difficult to respond to individual threats with specialized counters, as the other Hives seem to possess. Had I some Antinium in armor—or better, one of the Silent Antinium, I would feel far better able to eliminate threats with less casualties.”

The other Workers had kept chattering away as Yellow Splatters stewed. Anand sighed as he stood over the map, playing with one of the chess pieces he and Belgrade were using as markers. He lifted a rook and showed it to the others.

“The problem is that when we speak of units with self-preservation instincts, the autonomy to make their own decisions, and so on...the chess analogy falls apart. While I appreciate the game, it really does not reflect the battle I have been through, Belgrade.”

The other Worker nodded hesitantly.

“And yet, Anand, it is still important because it teaches strategic thinking. Why else would so many [Tacticians] and [Strategists] play the game?”

“Because it makes one level. That is self-evident. My issue is that I do not understand why [Strategists] level because of the game.”

Anand frowned, the Antinium equivalent of lowering his mandibles and drawing them together slightly.

“I could understand a low-level [Tactician] benefiting from the game, but earning more than five or six levels seems incredibly suspect. That a high-level [Strategist] could level up by playing a game with set, finite rules that is so far removed from a real battle or war is...odd. I would almost suspect an error in the way we level.”

“An error in the way we level? That means an error in the world.”

Belgrade stared at Anand. The other [Tactician] merely shrugged.

“I only state what is apparent. Regardless, exploiting this benefit is useful to us and the Hive as a whole. Shall we play a game once you are done with your duties?”

“Yes. Pawn, would you like to join in?”

“Hm. I do not know. I have things I should be doing...but chess is a tempting offer.”

Pawn glanced hesitantly at Yellow Splatters. He tried not to shift from leg to leg in impatience. *He* wasn't interested in chess at all. Why was he still here?

Someone apparently agreed with him. Purple Smile raised a hand and all four Antinium stared at him. When he was sure he had their attention, Purple Smile faced the Workers and pointed with two of his arms down the tunnel. With his other two arms, he mimed walking with his two spade-like hands. It was clumsy, but it got the message across.

“Oh, I apologize. We did not mean to keep you, Yellow Splatters, Purple Smile. You may go, of course.”

Anand straightened, twitching his antennae apologetically at the two. Yellow Splatters stared in disbelief. He didn’t feel relieved to be dismissed. He was angry. *Again.*

Purple Smile had no right to—the effrontery of—why hadn’t Yellow Splatters—he stomped after Purple Smile as the other Soldier wandered off. Yellow Splatters pointed, and the other Soldiers hastily fell into a line behind him as he marched back to the barracks. All the while his mind was racing.

Purple Smile. Pawn. The Workers. They were all so, so...*shortsighted!* They didn’t appreciate Yellow Splatter’s opinions, didn’t care, didn’t ask—and Purple Smile was inferior to Yellow Splatters! He was the [Sergeant]! He knew what was best! He had done everything right. Soldiers had to fight. They didn’t retreat, they didn’t run—and yet, Purple Smile had been praised. He was being considered for [Sergeant] as well, as an equal to Yellow Splatters!

Unacceptable. Why? And why had Twin Stripes become Aberration? Why was he locked up? Was it his fault? Why did Pawn look at him like that? Why were they fighting near the entrance? Why did he feel like he was losing control? Yellow Splatters’ mind was confused. He marched, not seeing the Workers he nearly ran over, or the way his Soldiers hesitated as they followed him—the wrong way—through the Hive. He was too preoccupied, too caught up in his anger and frustration.

He did not understand.

It was all going wrong. Lyonette had felt everything going south the last few days, but the final confirmation was seeing the Goblins smuggling some of their breakfast into the basement. That meant one thing. They were planning on leaving soon. And meanwhile, the tension in the inn was so thick that even a knife would bounce off it. She had to talk to Erin. Unfortunately, after an incident in the morning, that meant doing it as she slowly poured a healing potion over Erin's feet.

"Ow, ow! It hurts! Do you have anything to get the shards out with, Lyonette? I can feel one stuck *in* my foot!"

Erin moaned and winced as she sat in a chair, her bare feet pointed towards Lyonette. Blood dripped onto the floor, but Lyonette could still see the shards of porcelain that had buried themselves in the sole of Erin's foot.

"I see it, Erin. It's big. I'll try to get it out. Hold still."

Lyonette had a handkerchief in one hand, a healing potion in the other. She gently tried to grasp the bit of pottery, but it was slippery with blood and she didn't want to break it and leave it in Erin's skin. Neither did she want to use the healing potion right away; that might mean flesh growing over the shards and that would be bad. Erin whimpered as Lyonette concentrated; Mrsha sat anxiously by the table, eyes wide, watching.

It had happened this morning. Someone had broken an empty cup on the ground in front of the trap door leading to the basement and sprinkled the shards around. The porcelain was sharp and would have cut the Goblins' feet badly if they had stepped on it. Unfortunately or perhaps, fortunately, Erin had tried to go to the basement first and gotten several shards through the light soles of her shoes.

"Stop wiggling, Erin. If I slip—"

"I'm trying, but it hurts! Ow! Okay, do it."

Erin gritted her teeth and stopped moving. Lyonette took a deep breath, then grabbed the largest shard with her handkerchief and *pulled*. It came loose with a horrible, tearing sensation and she saw Erin bite into her lip, drawing blood. Lyonette pulled the shard out and immediately poured healing potion on the spot. The wound closed and she saw Mrsha's wide eyes going to the bloody shard. Lyonette bit her lip.

"Do you think the Goblins did this?"

"No. There's another piece—"

"I see it."

Neither girl looked at Mrsha as they spoke. The Goblins had been the first to hear Erin scream, and Headscratcher had carried Erin to the table. They'd let Lyonette take over, and, because Mrsha was there, they were in the basement now. Lyonette could only imagine what they thought of all this.

She glanced at Mrsha and saw the Gnoll staring with wide eyes at the blood dripping to the floor. Lyonette felt her chest twist and saw Erin looking at the Gnoll as well. Both paused for a second, and then kept talking about the Goblins because that was easier, for the moment.

"I think they're leaving, Erin. I saw, uh...Shorthilt hiding several biscuits in his pants when he was going downstairs. And Badarrow had several sausages—he wasn't trying to hide it. They're going, Erin."

"Biscuits? But those pants aren't large enough to—where were they hiding—never mind. Look, if they go...they go. But I'm going to have them upstairs and having fun today Lyonette, if it's the last thing I do!"

Erin gritted her teeth as Lyonette's fingers slipped on the second shard. Lyonette stared at the [Innkeeper].

“Why are you doing this, Erin? Really? Do you want them to stay? The Halfseekers haven’t eaten dinner here the last few nights, and no one’s coming in. We can’t keep doing this.”

“I know. I’m just—ahh! Just trying to get them to talk to me, Lyonette. If I can do that, I think it’ll be okay. I just want to talk to them, to understand them before they go. But it’s not happening no matter how hard I try.”

Erin closed her eyes as the second shard came out. Lyonette stared at it, pulled another sliver out of Erin’s foot, and then healed the rest. Some of the color rushed back into Erin’s face and she got up very gingerly.

“Thanks, Lyonette.”

“Don’t mention it. Okay, look, talk to the Goblins. I’ll—clean up I guess —”

“I’ll do it!”

Drassi had been hovering by the two Human girls the entire time, wringing her claws and looking horrified. She had already swept up the other fragments. Lyonette nodded gratefully.

“Okay. You do that, Drassi. Erin will serve the Goblins breakfast and I’ll—go upstairs with Mrsha and have a talk.”

Erin paused as she looked down at the white Gnoll sitting by her feet. Mrsha wasn’t looking at anyone and she was trembling slightly. She looked at Lyonette and nodded.

“Okay.”

She stepped gingerly towards the trap door, keeping an eye out for fragments as Lyonette washed her hands in a bucket of water and then looked at Mrsha.

“Come with me, young lady.”

The Gnoll flinched and followed Lyonette upstairs to their room. Once there, Lyonette sat, heart pounding, as Mrsha sat near her bed and pretended to be *very* interested in the covers.

How was she supposed to do this? She didn’t remember her mother ever sitting her down like this. Her father—his disapproval had been frightening, but he’d never really talked to her one-on-one before. And yet, Lyonette had never done something like this. She’d caused trouble, but it had been her [Tutors] and other guardians who had taken her to task for it. But this?

She did what she could. Lyonette spoke, voice trembling but trying to sound stern rather than heartbroken.

“That was a very bad thing that happened to Erin, don’t you think, Mrsha? She looked like she was really hurt.”

The Gnoll glanced up at Lyonette, and then away, swiftly. Lyonette paused.

“It looked like it hurt. It was *very* bad. Wasn’t it?”

The Gnoll nodded slowly. She still wouldn’t meet Lyonette’s gaze. That was what broke the girl’s heart. Oh, if only she could blame it on the Goblins or anyone else. But Mrsha was a poor liar. She folded her arms and tried not to let the stinging in her eyes become tears. It wasn’t right what she’d done. It wasn’t right, but Lyonette understood it.

“Do you know anything about this?”

The Gnoll shook her head half-heartedly. Lyonette gulped and raised her voice.

“Mrsha, look at me.”

Reluctantly, she did. Lyonette met her gaze, her fingernails digging into her arm.

“Do you know anything about this?”

The Gnoll looked away. That was an answer. Lyonette hesitated.

“Erin was in a lot of pain because of that, Mrsha. She could have been hurt worse. What if she’d stepped on the shards and one broke off in her foot? She’d need a [Healer] to cut it out of her, then.”

Mrsha began to tremble in place. Lyonette felt her heart breaking and stopped because she couldn’t go on.

“Maybe it wasn’t meant for her. Maybe that—trap—was meant for someone else. Like the Goblins. Well, if it was, it still wouldn’t be nice, understand?”

Something changed. Mrsha’s head slowly rose. She stared at Lyonette, and the guilt and sadness in her eyes dried up. Lyonette realized she might have chosen the wrong words.

“Mrsha. Hurting the Goblins isn’t right. Understand? You can’t—”

Mrsha’s hair was rising. She sat up straighter, and glared at Lyonette. The Human girl hesitated.

“I know how you must be feeling—”

Wrong words. Mrsha looked away from Lyonette and the young woman snapped.

“Mrsha! You can’t harm the Goblins! These are Erin’s guests and they’re all Hobs, understand? If you cause trouble, I will punish you. In fact, I’m already punishing you—no lunch!”

The Gnoll looked back towards Lyonette and now her eyes were glaring. Lyonette glared back.

“No lunch, and it’ll be water and bread for dinner unless you go to Erin and apologize, understand? And if I ever catch you doing that again—are you listening?”

Mrsha reluctantly turned back towards Lyonette. Her ears were flat, her eyes alight with anger. The Goblins. Lyonette wavered between compassion and anger, and lost.

“Look, Mrsha. You don’t have to go near them. You can go to the city if—no? You don’t want to stay with Aunt Selys? Okay. But Erin’s very hurt, even if she didn’t say it. You know it hurt? Don’t cry. Don’t—come here.”

She reached out and gathered up the Gnoll into her arms. Mrsha wept silently, big tears rolling down her furred face. Lyonette hugged her, as her mother never had, and tried to say the right things. Only, she’d never heard them herself.

“It’s okay. I know you’re sorry. You can apologize—we’ll do it together. It’s okay, Mrsha. You’re not a bad girl. It’s just—”

She didn’t have the words to express it. Lyonette held Mrsha for a long time, until the tears had stopped. Then they went downstairs.

Erin was cleaning up the tables, and the Goblins were finishing their breakfast. Lyonette froze and Mrsha’s claws dug into her clothing, but she made herself go downstairs. Erin met them by the stairs, smiling, and Lyonette had Mrsha apologize there, while both girls shielded the Goblins from view. Mrsha still smelled them, though. Her nose kept twitching even as she licked Erin’s face and hugged her and was hugged in return.

“Hey, at least I can get Drassi to buy some more cups. We need more—specially designed ones, I think. The Soldiers can’t hold the regular ones,

and I'd like them to have better bowls, too."

The tone Erin used was light and playful as she spoke to Mrsha, but from the disappointment in her eyes, Lyonette knew she hadn't gotten through to the Goblins today either. She'd seen Erin sitting at the table, trying to get them to talk to her, telling bad jokes, showing them how to play chess—there was no real connection there, and no one else was trying. Lately, Erin had gotten desperate and inventive.

"I've got a guitar that no one needs, now. I saw it in the market and I thought it would be *so cool* to play, but—I don't know how."

Erin showed Lyonette and Mrsha a strange instrument that reminded Lyonette of a warped lute. Mrsha plucked at a string and her ears perked up at the sound. Lyonette stared at Erin. The [Innkeeper] tried to play something, and the guitar made a strangled noise.

"That's a what, Erin? A gui..."

"Guitar. It's an instrument. Don't they have them where you come from? The Gnoll said it's not very popular, so he sold it to me cheap!"

"I can see why."

Lyonette looked at the guitar, at Erin, and then back at the guitar.

"Why did you buy this?"

"Oh, you know."

Erin made a face and nodded covertly towards the Goblins. Lyonette saw and felt Mrsha tensing up. She shifted with the Gnoll cub in her arms.

"Erin..."

"I know. Look, if I could play it—turns out they don't know how. I think they thought it was a weapon. I guess music isn't...never mind."

Erin turned towards the Goblins, smiling, and they all looked away from her. They had been looking, Lyonette thought, but she was distracted by Mrsha's claws digging into her arm.

“Ow! Mrsha, honey. You're hurting me.”

The Gnoll withdrew her claws, but she remained taut in Lyonette's arms. She was shaking, and Lyonette thought it was time to go back upstairs. The Goblins were glancing their way. She saw one of them, Headscratcher, looking furtively at her. Lyonette looked away and realized he'd done the same. And like that, in a flash, she realized the Goblins knew she was afraid of them. It was obvious with Drassi—but they could probably tell that Lyonette was too.

“Erin, I'm taking Mrsha upstairs. Sorry, but I won't be down for a bit.”

“That's okay. Drassi's here and it's not like we have much business, right?”

Erin gave her a strained smile. Lyonette thought about returning it, and didn't. She turned towards the stairs as Erin went back towards the Goblins. The girl sat close to them, but not close enough to touch. The Goblins stared back, and there was that invisible wall between them that Erin couldn't breach.

“Hey...so, sorry about that. I uh, have I showed you this guitar? Yes? Okay. Um—”

It wasn't working. Lyonette didn't know if it was something Erin lacked, or something she wasn't doing, but as it was, she thought she'd wake up tomorrow or the day after and they would be gone. And would that be such a bad thing?

Part of Lyonette wished they would leave. Maybe it was for the best. Mrsha stared at the Goblins as Lyonette carried her upstairs. Her eyes

narrowed and she growled. She still hated them. Erin getting hurt had done nothing to change that, and so Lyonette resolved to watch the little Gnoll until they were gone.

It was all going wrong. And that was *before* the Antinium came again. Then it went wrong and got worse.

Yellow Splatters decided that Purple Smile was unfit to be a [Sergeant]. He might be unfit to be a Painted Soldier. Could he stay somewhere else? He was so...so different! He didn't spar when all the other Soldiers were copying Yellow Splatters' example, he liked going aboveground, and he didn't fight like a proper Soldier.

He didn't belong in Yellow Splatters' unit. And that thought was incredible and troubling. So Yellow Splatters didn't think about it. He stared at Purple Smile as the other Soldier wandered around the barracks, following...what? He'd rolled up a ball out of dirt and wet it with some water. Now he was rolling it around, following after it, picking it up and tossing it, and following it again.

He was too strange. Yellow Splatters didn't know how to address it, but he was working up to some good ideas when Pawn walked into the barracks with eight Workers and spoke.

"Purple Smile? Your patrol for this morning awaits. Please take these Workers above as well with the regular group of Soldiers."

Purple Smile turned and nodded. Yellow Splatters looked at Pawn in astonishment. Hadn't he made it clear what a waste that patrol was? But then—Workers. They were...acceptable? Yellow Splatters was undecided.

But he froze when he saw the two Soldiers standing behind the Workers and saw eight more of the Painted Soldiers, *his* Soldiers coming forwards.

They stopped when he looked at them. Yellow Splatters struggled internally. He'd made it clear—but if they wanted to eat—but *he* had shown them—maybe it was only for security? Pawn stared between Purple Smile and Yellow Splatters, and then nodded to Purple Smile.

“I have no objections to you taking Painted Soldiers. Go. And remember what I told you.”

Purple Smile nodded to Pawn, and pointed. The regular Workers and Soldiers lined up meekly, and the eight Painted Soldiers fell into line behind them after a moment's pause. None of them looked at Yellow Splatters. He stared at them and felt an emotion rising in his being. He had to struggle to find the word to express it.

Disobedience. Betrayal. He raised his head and stared at the Soldiers, and then at Purple Smile. This was *his* fault. But what could he do? The other Antinium was already leading them out of the Hive—

The convoy of Antinium jerked as Yellow Splatters strode towards them. But he fell meekly into place behind the last Soldier. Purple Smile stared at him for eight seconds, and then slowly moved the procession forwards again. Yellow Splatters raised his mandibles. He was just coming along, that was all. Just to remind the other Soldiers, remind Purple Smile who was in charge.

They made it to the inn just past lunchtime. The Goblins were eating, and the Horns of Hammerad had found their way into the inn as well. The Halfseekers were quietly talking in one corner of the room and eying the Goblins. A Gnoll had come from the city for the first time in over a week, and Mrsha had crept downstairs with a wand in her paw without anyone noticing.

Apista was napping by the faerie flowers blooming on the windowsill. The Horns of Hammerad were arguing, covered in mud after hunting a pack of regular, hungry wolves. Erin was hugging Ishkr. Lyonette smiled as she wiped a table and listened to them talk.

“I’m so glad you’re back! Are you okay? If you need more time off, I understand. I just...”

The Gnoll looked embarrassed as he stood in the inn, his red-brown fur engulfing Erin as she hugged him. He growled apologetically.

“I am fine, Miss Erin. I apologize for my absence. It was inexcusable. If you wish to dock my pay—”

“Don’t be stupid! How could I not get it? I know—I can’t believe Brunkr—”

Erin wiped her stinging eyes on Ishkr’s fur. The Goblins stared furtively at the Gnoll and he looked at them.

“I see we have new guests. I did not believe it when I heard the rumors, yes? Miss Erin, would you like me to serve them? Miss Erin? Would you let go of me?”

“Oops. Sorry.”

Erin let go of Ishkr and smiled with genuine pleasure for the first time in days.

“We’re getting lunch out. If you don’t mind serving that’d be great. And we could use some more water, although it’s wet outside.”

“I can get it! Nothing like wet Gnolls to stink up a place. Hi Ishkr!”

Drassi smiled and waved at the Gnoll. He smiled back, not seemingly bothered about the wet Gnolls comment, and began serving the Goblins with only a moment of hesitation. Ishkr was quiet, but he seemed resolved to do his job today.

That was all Erin and Lyonette wanted right now. The Antinium had come back as usual, only, Lyonette was sure it *wasn't* like usual this time.

“Erin, that Soldier with the yellow paint is back. And I think he and Purple Smile are *not* getting along.”

Lyonette hissed at Erin as the Antinium took a table close to the doors. It was a mark of how the relationships in the inn were different that when they sat, it was next to the Horns of Hammerad while the Goblins sat on the other side of the room. Add in the Halfseekers, and there were three zones of tension and a very narrow pathway down the center of the inn that was, in theory, neutral ground.

Erin and Lyonette stood there, talking, while Drassi came in with more water, complaining about melting snow and Ishkr brought out plates. The Halfseekers and Goblins were staring at each other silently, but Lyonette could only devote half an eye to them—she was more worried about the Antinium. As far as she was concerned, the way the Antinium with yellow splatters was acting required an eye and a half. At least.

“He’s that guy who poured his food on the ground, right?”

Erin frowned at Yellow Splatters as the [Sergeant] sat at his table, looking around with all four arms folded across his chest. Purple Smile was waving at her and she waved back with a smile to him. Then she turned to Lyonette.

“Okay, serve him *last* and let the other Antinium begin eating first. If he does that again, I’ll talk to them. But I’m worried about the Halfseekers too. Jelaqua’s not looking happy.”

“Of course she’s not! But she probably won’t start a fight.”

“You sure? Right, just don’t serve her anything strong, okay? Feed her, don’t let her drink. A happy Selphid’s a fat Selphid. Or something.”

Lyonette smiled and hurried off. Erin circulated the tables, smiling at everyone and not getting many smiles in return. The Goblins were muttering to themselves, the Halfseekers looked like they were having an argument. Ceria and Ksmvr were helping get some mud off Yvlon and Pisces was complaining about his order to Erin. The Antinium were just—just sitting there, waiting for their food.

And then it happened. There was a *yelp* and Headscratcher sat up in his seat. Instantly, the room tensed. Erin turned, and saw Jelaqua and the Halfseekers half-risen from their chairs.

“Wait, wait!”

She shouted at them as Lyonette stared at Headscratcher. He was grimacing, raising one of his arms. It rose over the edge of the table and, hanging from it, her teeth still buried in his arm, was Mrsha.

“*Mrsha!*”

Lyonette cried out in horror and rushed forwards. Headscratcher regarded the Gnoll, wincing as she growled and bit into his arm. She refused to let go, and the Goblin didn’t seem inclined to make her let go. He had frozen with the other Goblins. Badarrow watched Lyonette tensely and moved back, eying the Halfseekers, and Lyonette went over to Headscratcher and Mrsha.

“I am *so sorry*. Mrsha! Let go now, little miss! I mean it! Let go *now* or —”

Mrsha let go and dropped onto the table. She growled, her eyes flashing. Her mouth was red with blood. Lyonette froze. There was more than a bit of

feral animal in the small Gnoll. Ishkr growled something at her and she snarled wordlessly at him. Erin turned back towards the table, concerned. Across the room Ceria whispered to her team.

“What’s wrong with Mrsha?”

The Gnoll was growling at the Goblins. Headscratcher leaned back, not so much afraid as wary. Lyonette seized Mrsha and waved desperately at Drassi and Ishkr.

“Keep serving! I’ll—Mrsha, you’re apologizing. *Now!*”

The Gnoll fought her, clawing at Lyonette, snapping. Lyonette could barely hold on, and Erin was hurrying over to her when the second thing happened. Ishkr went over to the Antinium, holding bowls of ground beef seasoned with hot pepper and a fried egg on top. He passed it to Purple Smile, and the Soldier passed it to a Worker. And Yellow Splatters lost his temper.

Yellow Splatters had seen Mrsha sneaking downstairs and underneath the Goblins’ table. The Gnoll was quite good at concealing herself despite her white fur. Perhaps only he had seen it; the other Antinium were too focused on the smells of cooking and the other people in the room were all glaring at each other.

He didn’t care, but when Mrsha bit the Goblin, Yellow Splatters appreciated her ferocity. The smell of blood and the sudden, sharp spike of tension and scent of fear—he felt like he was on the battlefield again.

That was good. But he stared at Purple Smile and hated the other Antinium for everything he was, everything he was not. Part of Yellow

Splatters knew it didn't make sense, but he didn't care. He was just angry. Frustrated. He was in charge, but *eight* of his Painted Soldiers had still come here! And Pawn and Anand and Belgrade all liked Purple Smile. And why had Twin Stripes become Aberration?

Then the Gnoll with red-brown fur came over and handed a bowl of food to Purple Smile. He shouldn't have done that. He should have served Yellow Splatters first, but the [Sergeant] was prepared to overlook that. What he wasn't willing to forgive was when Purple Smile took the bowl *and handed it to a Worker*.

A Worker. Not a Soldier. Not one of the warriors who risked his life to fight day and night for the Hive, who gave their lives—Yellow Splatters' four hands clenched into fists as the Worker hesitantly accepted the bowl. It looked up at Purple Smile, and the Soldier raised his mandibles and gestured for the Worker to begin eating.

That was it. That was the last straw! Yellow Splatters rose and flipped the table over. The Worker and other Soldiers flinched back as he charged around the table at Purple Smile. The other Soldier leapt to his feet, and then Yellow Splatters was punching at him, trying to bash the Antinium's head in.

“What the—”

The Horns of Hammerad were on their feet. Ksmvr leapt to his feet and thrust Yvlon back as the adventurers reached for their weapons. Purple Smile and Yellow Splatters ignored the cries of alarm throughout the rest of the room. There was only the two Soldiers, face-to-face, mandibles nearly touching, each one throwing punches, blocking, dodging as they fought.

Yellow Splatters knew he had the advantage. He was bigger, stronger thanks to his classes, and he had the [Tough Carapace] and [Power Strike] Skills. Only, he wouldn't use [Power Strike]; he'd just beat Purple Smile

within an inch of his life to prove to everyone who was right! He lashed out and Purple Smile dodged backwards, two hands raised protectively, the other two warding off punches.

“You two Antinium desist! I am Ksmvr, former Prognugator of the Hive and you are causing a public disturbance in—”

He was doing it again! Yellow Splatters clashed his mandibles together, throwing punches at Purple Smile. He was retreating! Running away! The Soldier was dancing backwards, refusing to let Yellow Splatters get a clear shot at him. All of Yellow Splatters’ blows were blocked or deflected. The other Soldier tried to express his fury as he charged forwards.

This wasn’t right! He should be undefeatable. Purple Smile shouldn’t be fighting equally with him! No one should listen to him! It was Yellow Splatters who had all the answers! Only his opinion mattered! He was right! He couldn’t be wrong! He was right! *hE wAs RIghT!*

“Enough!”

Erin was pushing towards them, but two of the Goblins were thrusting her back. One had a sword in his hand and was rising, wary and tense. Another was fiddling with a bow. Across the room, the half-Giant was arguing with his companions, raising his staff. The Horns of Hammerad were similarly caught in indecision, tense, waiting for the stalemate between the two Soldiers to break. Every eye was on the Soldiers now, and Lyonette’s grip on Mrsha had loosened.

The Gnoll took the chance. She wriggled out of Lyonette’s grip, kicked off from the stunned young woman, and leapt onto the table with the Goblins. They were all distracted. The Gnoll reached for the wand she’d hidden with a bit of string on her furry body. She tore it loose and ran towards Badarrow. She raised the tip of the long, thin, pointy magical wand, and then she thrust it *into his ear*.

Time slowed. Lyonette saw Mrsha thrusting with the wand, the hard, thin stiletto of wood. It was aimed right at Badarrow's pointed ears, and it went into his earhole, towards his brain.

Only Badarrow's warrior reflexes saved him. The Goblin *twisted* at the last moment and the wand was torn out of Mrsha's grip. It flew across the room, and Badarrow clutched at his left ear. Blood trickled from it as the Goblins jerked and stared at Mrsha. She snarled, bared her teeth—

“Mrsha!”

Erin's voice was shocked. Lyonette didn't wait for words. The horror of what Mrsha had done, tried to do, moved her body. She grabbed Mrsha. The Gnoll wriggled, hissing, biting in her grip—Lyonette flipped her over and began to spank her with all her might.

At first, the shock of what was happening froze Mrsha, but then she was wriggling, yowling in pain, trying to get away. Lyonette held her in place, spanking the Gnoll hard, tears in her eyes.

“*You do not do that!* Understand? How could you? *You do not do that, Mrsha!*”

The Gnoll was crying now, from the pain as much as Lyonette's shouting. Lyonette kept going, trying to tell the Gnoll, remembering the tip of the wand going into Badarrow's ear—she only stopped when someone grabbed her hand.

Headscratcher stopped Lyonette's arm as it rose for another swat. The Goblin looked at Mrsha, and Lyonette saw the Gnoll's face was streaked

with tears. Mrsha leapt from the table and raced upstairs. Lyonette sank to the floor, sobbing.

Across the room, the fight between Purple Smile and Yellow Splatters had reached its conclusion. The [Sergeant] had cornered Purple Smile and was bashing through his guard. The other Soldier was blocking but his guard was failing. A few more blows and Yellow Splatters would be tearing his carapace off, beating him into pieces—

The cold prick of metal jabbed into his side, painful, making him break off. Yellow Splatters turned and froze. A shortsword was at his neck—an arrow trained on his face. Ksmvr held both his shortbow and shortsword with his three hands. He shifted the arrow to Purple Smile.

“Hold still, both of you. This fight is over.”

The two Soldiers froze in place, staring at Ksmvr. The Antinium’s voice wobbled a bit, but steadied as he continued.

“I am a former Prognugator of the Hive. That gives me no authority.”

He paused. The Soldiers glanced at him and each other. Ksmvr pressed his sword further into Yellow Splatter’s side.

“No authority. At all. But I am led to understand that this sword gives me all the authority I need. Move and I will injure you non-lethally but in a very painful way.”

The two Soldiers didn’t move. The other Antinium were on their feet, staring at them. The Goblins were clustered around Badarrow. He looked expressionlessly around, one hand clamped to an ear leaking blood. The Halfseekers were staring, the Horns of Hammerad were ready to defend Ksmvr. Lyonette was crying, Drassi and Ishkr were uncertain.

And Erin knew what she had to do. She stepped towards Lyonette and Apista buzzed off the windowsill. She flew around, stinger protruding

dangerously. Erin took a cautious step and Apista landed on her arm. Erin looked at the Ashfire Bee and lost her temper.

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The inn was tense silence. Erin's heart was in pieces over Mrsha, and she was afraid for Ksmvr, confused about the Antinium. She looked at Badarrow, bleeding, expressionless, and her heart broke in a different way. And then there was the bee.

Apista fanned her wings dangerously as she slowly extended her stinger on her abdomen. Erin stared at the Ashfire Bee coldly.

"Sting me, and Lyonette will have to sweep you up, Apista. Understand?"

The air around her froze and the bee hesitated. Slowly she withdrew her stinger and flew off Erin's arm. She landed on a table and hid behind a mug. Erin nodded. She took a deep breath.

"Okay. Everyone? *Freeze.*"

It wasn't so much the words as the atmosphere that came with it. A chill and a pause swept through the inn, which halted the adventurers, the Antinium, and the Goblins where they stood or sat and drew every eye to Erin. She nodded.

"Good. Now, the first person who moves I will personally break their arm. No one stands, draws a sword, or does anything until I say they can. Got it? Good."

She looked around. The room was quiet. Erin bent and went to Lyonette.

"Lyonette?"

The young woman was crying.

“I had to—I couldn’t—”

“I know. But Badarrow’s fine. Lyonette, look at me.”

The [Princess] did, eyes red, nose dribbling. Erin gripped her arms.

“Go upstairs.”

“But—”

“You don’t have to go into the room. Just sit outside it and make sure Mrsha doesn’t go anywhere, okay? Can you do that?”

Lyonette hesitated, and then brushed at her nose. That only made things worse.

“I—I can. Okay.”

She got up slowly. Erin looked around. Next? Goblins. Antinium. The Goblins were staring. She pointed at Drassi and the Drake flinched.

“Healing potion, Drassi! Give it to Badarrow. Now, as for you—”

She turned to the tableau of frozen Antinium. All three of them stared at her as she walked over. Ksmvr had the tip of his shortsword jammed into Yellow Splatters’ side. A trickle of green blood was running down the length of the blade. Erin stared at Ksmvr.

“Put your sword down.”

He hesitated.

“Miss Erin—”

“I said, *down*, Ksmvr. Bow as well.”

He reluctantly obeyed. The other two Soldiers shifted when he did. Yellow Splatters began to raise his fist and Purple Smile tried to slide away

across the wall. Erin stamped her foot and there was a localized tremor. The Antinium went still.

“You three, sit. Now.”

They looked at her, confused. Erin stared at them. There was a...look in her eyes. A suggestion that she might be willing to beat all three to death with her bare hands if she was not obeyed. The look of a Prognugator of a Hive.

“I said, *sit*.”

All three Antinium sat down. The two Soldiers and Ksmvr looked up at Erin from their cross-legged positions on the floor. She eyed them but decided not to comment.

“Good. Now, keep sitting. If any of you three move, I will have Moore come over and hit you. And if that doesn’t work, I’ll get Jelaqua to do it.”

She nodded at the Halfseekers. They stared at her. Erin flashed them a smile and walked over to the Goblins.

“I am very, very sorry about what Mrsha did.”

She said that to Badarrow first off. He stared at her and his face twisted into a sneer reminiscent of Pisces. He had already poured healing potion into his ear and was tilting his head to hold it in. Erin hoped his eardrum hadn’t been punctured, or if it had, the healing potion would fix it. She looked at him and around the table.

“I mean it. That was inexcusable and shouldn’t have happened in my inn. You have my word she won’t do it again.”

The other four Goblins shifted in their seats and looked at each other. One gave Erin a half-hearted nod, and another shrugged.

There. That was what Erin felt, had been feeling this entire time. That sense of...disconnect. They didn't believe her. Or if they did, they thought she wouldn't be able to keep her word. Or—they were Goblins. They were used to being attacked. That was life.

And that was wrong. Erin hesitated just for a moment. But this was it. She felt what she had to do at last. She reached out and *touched* Badarrow. She grabbed his hands with hers, feeling his hands—warm and real, in hers.

He jerked, a trickle of potion and blood spilling out of one ear. Reflexively he tried to pull his hands away but Erin wouldn't let him. She held his hands. His fingernails were long, yes, and his skin was green. Of course. But they were warm hands, and she could feel his pulse. It was accelerating. He was nervous. And as she stared into his crimson eyes, she saw a person there.

“There you are. I knew you were like me.”

He didn't understand. Erin smiled at him. She leaned closer, and now she could smell him, and he couldn't look away. She looked into his eyes and spoke.

“I am sorry about Mrsha. But she has a reason to hate you. Goblins killed her tribe.”

He flinched at that. All the Goblins did. They looked at Erin and away. They understood what she meant in a heartbeat, of course, but they tried to distance themselves. They tried to hide, in what they were and what she was. Goblins and a Human. Two species destined for conflict. They had given their hearts away once and lost them. They didn't want to feel. But Erin was too close. Badarrow couldn't look away.

“It was recently. A few months ago. And when she came here...I think she's afraid you'll kill her. I know you won't. But I'm asking you to forgive her. I know she tried to kill you. But she's a child. I'll try to get her to come

downstairs. I'm not asking you to do anything—but I hope you understand.”

Badarrow glanced into Erin's eyes and away. He tried to turn his head, but she kept drawing him back. And then he looked at her as if intoxicated. They were close. She was real. And so was he. He nodded slowly and Erin smiled.

“Thank you. And I want you to know that I had a friend, once. Her name was Rags and she was a Goblin. She and I didn't always understand each other, but I thought of her as a friend, as a person. I think you're people too.”

The Goblins stared at her. Badarrow's face was filled with expressions the other Redfang warriors had seldom seen. Shock, surprise, and then...a smile. As if he couldn't help it. Erin smiled and looked around.

“Wait, please. Ishkr? Give them food and make sure everyone has something to eat. I'll be down shortly.”

She strode towards the stairs and took them two at a time. She looked back only once. Badarrow was staring at his hands and another Goblin, Shorthilt, was prodding at his palms. He looked up and met her eyes. And she smiled at him and knew he was embarrassed. All that Goblin mystique, all the tension, the uncertainty—she'd forgotten that if you looked into someone's eyes, you could see their soul. And it shone brightly in the Goblin's gaze.

Upstairs was different than below. The murmuring below and thawing of shock was at odds with the sound of crying above. Mrsha was sobbing and Lyonette was in tears. Erin strode towards the door to their room and opened it. Lyonette hovered at the doorway. Erin turned to her.

“I think I need to talk to Mrsha by herself.”

Lyonette hesitated, and then nodded. She went downstairs and Erin went inside. She found Mrsha curled up in her bedroll, quivering and making sobbing sounds, although of course she couldn't fully articulate them. She had no voice, but some things were wordless. Erin reached out and the ball *jerked* under the covers. A head poked out and Mrsha stared at her.

"Mrsha—"

The Gnoll swiped at her with a paw. Erin caught the paw gently and looked at the Gnoll.

"We need to talk."

Mrsha didn't want to talk. She wanted to be sad. She wanted to hurt. Erin understood that, but she also had to be heard. So she compromised. She held Mrsha's paw and stroked it. At first, the Gnoll tried to pull away, but then she gave up and lay there, weeping, as Erin patted her head and stroked her fur. After a while, Erin felt it was time to speak.

"I should have talked with you a long time ago about this, Mrsha. About the Goblins, I mean."

The Gnoll froze up and her paw was suddenly sharp with claws in Erin's hand. The young woman adjusted her grip and sighed.

"Mrsha. Listen to me."

The Gnoll didn't want to listen. She pulled hard, and Erin pulled right back. Surprised, Mrsha tumbled out of her bedding and met Erin's eyes. The [Innkeeper] bent her head and spoke in a quiet, direct voice.

"Mrsha. Hating the Goblins is not wrong."

The Gnoll Cub froze. She looked up at Erin and the young woman nodded.

“No, it’s not. I should have said that to you earlier. Hating the Goblins isn’t wrong. They killed your tribe, your friends—why shouldn’t you hate them?”

Confusion. Mrsha stopped pulling and listened. Erin tugged her closer, until she was sitting across from Mrsha, very close. She met the Gnoll’s eyes.

“It’s not wrong. Anyone would hate them for that. Hating Goblins isn’t wrong. But hating all Goblins, hating *these* Goblins—that’s not right, either.”

The conversation had only one voice, but it was not one-sided. Mrsha narrowed her eyes and Erin went on.

“Listen, Mrsha. I am going to tell you something important. Something you have to learn. And it’s this: people are not the same. Understand?”

A silence. Uncomprehending. Pain.

“That’s all there is. People are not the same. Where I come from Mrsha, people look...well, we’re all Human. But we’re not all the same. Some of us have black skin, some have white skin, others have long hair—some are men and some are women. We are not all the same. Not all Humans are the same, right? That’s simple. You’re smart. You know that Lyonette and I aren’t the same, right?”

A smile and in return, a small nod. Puzzlement.

“But some people think that, oh, because Lyonette and I are both female that we’re the same. Or—they think all people with black skin are the same. And that’s not true. There are good people and bad people, Mrsha. And they might look alike in some ways, but they aren’t. I could look at Ishkr and Brunkr and if I was really silly, I’d say they look alike. But they’re not, are they?”

A quick shake of the head.

“No, no they aren’t. But some people think that way. In fact, most of us do it. We don’t mean to, but we do. And that means we judge everyone by the actions of a few. Like Goblins. They are not all the same.”

Eyes widening. Looking away, tense.

“Mrsha. Not all Goblins are the same. That is what I have to tell you. Just that.”

Just that? Looking back. A nod.

“That’s it. I’m not going to tell you all Goblins aren’t evil, or they aren’t all murderers, because then I’m talking about *all* of them. I’m just telling you that you can’t judge all of them without seeing them. Like the ones downstairs. They’re Goblins. But they haven’t hurt anyone. Aside from evil goats, that is.”

Looking down. Paw clenched. Erin lowered her voice softly.

“You don’t have to like them. I won’t ever make you do that.”

Mrsha looked up.

“I promise. You don’t even have to go near them. But you can’t hurt them. Because they’re not the ones who killed your tribe.”

The Gnoll began to shake. Erin drew her closer and hugged her.

“I’m sorry, Mrsha. They’re not. They might look like those Goblins, but they are not the same. They didn’t know. And you don’t have to like another Goblin if you don’t want to. You don’t have to forgive. Not right now. But you can’t blame them all for the same thing. They’re different. Like you and like me.”

Silence. Trembling. Erin tried to explain the last bit. The most important bit.

“I’m letting them stay here. Not because I think they’re innocent, but because I don’t think they’re *bad*. And Mrsha, they’ve given me no reason to distrust them. If they did, I would kick them out in an instant. Believe me. But they’ve done nothing bad. So that’s why I’m giving them a chance.”

She whispered to the Gnoll as she hugged her.

“They might not deserve a second chance. But everyone deserves a first one. That’s what I think. And you don’t have to like that. You don’t have to like them. But you do have to accept that that’s what I believe. And if you try to hurt them again, Mrsha—that can’t happen. Understand?”

The Gnoll looked down. She wasn’t crying now. She was just...lost. Erin looked at her.

“Here’s what I’m going to do. I’m going downstairs to sort the rest of this out, Mrsha. And you’re going to come with me.”

The Gnoll jolted in fear. Erin held her.

“You don’t have to do anything. You can sit with the Halfseekers. With Moore. And you’ll be safe, Mrsha. The Goblins won’t do anything. If they hurt you, if they do anything bad, you tell me and I will cut them up into little pieces. But I don’t think they will. If you see them doing something bad, you tell me. Otherwise, you come down this once, and then you can do what you want, okay?”

A long pause. Erin waited as Mrsha thought about this, as she struggled—and then nodded slowly. Erin bent and kissed her on the head.

“You’re very brave. And I know you’re hurting. Just remember what I told you. People are not the same. Now, let’s wipe that blood off and bring

you downstairs. You can eat something hot and we'll sort the rest of this out, okay?"

She reached out and a small Gnoll took her hand. And if Mrsha was afraid as they went downstairs, if she flinched from the Goblins, that was okay. She went willingly and sat next to Moore and Jelaqua, holding both their legs for support. That was all Erin had hoped for.

A start.

This was how it got better. With food, with enforced sitting, as the blood cooled and regrets took over. With an [Innkeeper], going around to each table, talking to people, holding hands—treating them as people. Yellow Splatters sat very still and didn't look around. He could sense the other Soldiers and Workers looking at him.

And he was lost. He didn't know what he'd done. He'd tried to *kill* Purple Smile at the end of it. Another Soldier. One of his brothers.

One of his people.

He was barely conscious of Erin moving around the room, and then her exasperatedly arguing with the Gnoll, Ishkr, over an object.

"Why did you buy this if you cannot play it? It seems like a waste of money, yes?"

"I thought I could learn! I want music, Ishkr, and I don't want to pay for a [Bard] or something. If I could teach myself—"

"Why not let me play?"

"Wait, you know how to play?"

Erin stared at the Gnoll in disbelief. Ishkr looked embarrassed and scratched behind one ear as Lyonette and Drassi passed out strong drinks for everyone.

“I play a bit. Not this instrument, but I have earned coins doing it before. Hrr. Ahem. This is similar to instruments I know, though. Still.”

He frowned at the guitar, looking at it dubiously.

“Why not an oud, or a mandolin? I’ve played a gittern, but this?”

Ishkr poked the guitar with one claw, looking dubious. Erin stared at him anxiously.

“I have no idea what those other things are. Most of the music from my country is on this...well, I guess there’s the violin, cello, and so on. Ukuleles...look, if you can play this, that’d be great.”

“Hrr. I can try.”

The Gnoll lifted the guitar and slung the strap around his shoulder. He strummed across the strings, making a sound that Erin hadn’t been able to after ten minutes of trying. Erin gasped with delight and hurried into the kitchen. Lyonette stared as Ishkr played a chord quickly and easily.

“Don’t your claws get in the way?”

Ishkr smiled at her.

“They do. I cut them short, but I’ve also learned to play with them. Many Gnoll instruments are made to be easier for my people to play anyways, though. And this is one.”

“Oh. No wonder Erin couldn’t play it.”

“Hrm? What? Humans could play it without much difficulty. Perhaps she is just, ah—”

He broke off as Erin came out of the kitchen. She had a bit of parchment in one hand and thrust it at him anxiously.

“I tried to write down songs in my spare time. Good ones from home. I can remember the lyrics, but the notes—I uh, I think I’ve gotten it mostly down. Could you—could you try playing this?”

Ishkr accepted the parchment and studied it. After a second he looked up.

“This—is not music, Miss Erin. I cannot read it.”

“What? No, it’s good music! Pop songs! Why can’t you play it?”

The Gnoll looked incredulously at her, and then shifted the parchment and pointed at a section.

“It says here...twang, twang, higher-pitched twang? How am I supposed to play that?”

Erin turned bright red and snatched the parchment back from him. Across the inn, a Goblin laughed out loud and then fell silent as everyone stared at him. But the laughter was good.

“I’m not good with music, okay? Look, how about this? Can you play something like—”

She hummed, and Ishkr tried to copy the sound. Erin broke off.

“No, not like that. Do it more like—double the sound here. Good! And make it lower. Longer—don’t glare at me! I know how it should sound in *my* head! Try another string. No, not that string. This string!”

As she argued with Ishkr, Lyonette went around the room, trying to serve the three different groups in the room and praying none of them would cause trouble. Surprisingly...they didn’t. The Antinium were sitting in a kind of meditative silence, Purple Smile and Yellow Splatters sitting

and staring at each other and at Erin. Yellow Splatters had his arms folded, but he didn't look like he was going to start another fight. He looked like he was sulking, actually.

The Goblins were listening to Erin and Ishkr, wincing every time he played a discordant note. But they seemed more entertained by this than they had by anything else. As for Mrsha and the adventurers—she was having her fur stroked by three different sets of hands at once as she stared at the Goblins. All was tranquil for now, and Lyonette conspired with Drassi and several mugs of alcohol to keep it that way.

“We’ve never served the Goblins *ale!*”

Drassi hissed at Lyonette as they filled up mugs by the bar. Lyonette shook her head. Really? They hadn't? But everyone drank. And yet, Lyonette couldn't remember ever serving the Goblins a real drink besides milk, juice, or water. That felt a bit...wrong, to her.

“So what? They're guests, Drassi. Fill the mugs and serve them, and help me find the stronger stuff. Where does Erin keep it? We'll try them on it, and if they don't like it, well, Jelaqua and Seborn drink like mules!”

The Drake grimaced, but didn't object. She pointed to the kitchen.

“Erin keeps it hidden behind the potatoes, remember? After Mrsha tried drinking some—”

“Right. Thanks!”

And then there was music. Lyonette went back into the common room and heard something. A melody. It was quiet, and had a few mistakes at the start, but there was a...feeling it carried. Just a few repeating notes on a guitar played by a Gnoll. But then Erin began to sing.

At first her voice was out of place. The guitar and her words were not enough. Erin frowned and looked around.

“Guess I don’t have an immortal moment. Hold on, we need a drum for this to work properly.”

She ran into the kitchen and grabbed a long wooden spoon and a wooden tong. After a moment Erin grabbed a large bowl and ran out. She plonked the bowl onto a table in front of Numbtongue. He stared at it.

“Can you give me a beat? And you—Headscratcher. I bet you can match my voice, right? I need a chorus.”

The Goblins gaped at her. But now the guitar solo had an accompaniment. Erin began to clap her hands rhythmically and Headscratcher was the first to copy. She turned.

“Come on, then! I need some help! Numbtongue, give me a beat.”

The Goblin picked up the spoon and began to hit the bowl. The sound was high—too high. Erin made him slap the bowl and then the Goblins began to pound on the table. She turned, and then she needed voices.

“Ceria? I know you can sing. Yvlon—Ksmvr? Pisces? Aw, don’t be like that. All you need to sing is this—now, I want a *beat!* Come on Numbtongue, hit that table!”

The Goblin slapped the table and there was something like a proper drumbeat. Ishkr bent over the notes, playing, and now Erin had a crowd. She pointed at the other Soldiers and Workers.

“I could use some clapping! Join in any time! Okay? Let’s start. I’ll start and you join in like this? Ready? One, two, three!”

And then there was music. It started out disjointed, and then it grew louder. Erin began to sing as the guitar’s melody became only one part of a symphony. Voices joined with hers, and the Goblins clapped and slapped the table to music. The first music they had heard.

Sitting by himself, Yellow Splatters tried to ignore it. He did. He tried to tell himself there were things that mattered more. He sat, hunched, trying not to listen. It was just sound.

But then he heard a Soldier begin to stomp on the floor. The voices of the singers blended with the beat. Yellow Splatters stared at the Soldier. He was thumping the floor with his feet, and then clapping his hands together clumsily. He knew Yellow Splatters was watching, but the other Soldier didn't care. And then another Soldier stood up. He began to beat a rhythm on the table with an empty cup, and the others joined in.

Now the beat ran through the inn. Erin stood in the center, laughing and singing. And one of the Goblins was singing too. Numbtongue had memorized every word. Across the inn, Moore was gently thumping the table as Mrsha bounced up and down. Jelaqua, Ceria, Yvlon—even Pisces was joining into the chorus. Drassi and Lyonette were singing as they passed around drinks.

And now the music was reaching into Yellow Splatters' mind, into his body, tugging at his heart, searching for his soul. He couldn't help it. He uncurled and his leg began jiggling to the beat. That was the start.

Erin paused the music and, amid cheering, began to teach them another song. She started with Ishkr, and then gave the others a beat and words to sing to. And the words reached into a place that Yellow Splatters had forgotten he had. He listened to Erin, a Human who knew nothing of his pain, sing. And somehow, the words were meant for him. She sang about home, about belonging, and the music broke Yellow Splatters' heart and healed it at the same time.

That was how it began. Erin knew a hundred songs, some which required guitars, some which required a beat, others which were solo. Some were sad, others tragic. Others made the people in the inn sit up and made the hearts beating inside race. Others made them dance. Erin grabbed

Headscratcher and linked arms with him. She began to dance with the surprised Goblin.

“Hey all of you! Is this a party or not? Come on! Show me how you dance!”

That was how it began. Yellow Splatters found himself dragged up and spun around. Soldiers didn’t know how to dance. But he found that there were no rules to it. He saw Purple Smile doing a two-step with Ksmvr across the floor, taught by an amused Erin. At one point Jelaqua took to the dance floor and began what the Antinium could only term as enthusiastic flailing. But it was so enjoyable that a Worker, Mrsha, and Drassi copied her.

Dancing was different. The music demanded it. Yellow Splatters found himself whirling, arms wide, spinning in place. And that was fun! And then Erin told them they were only getting started. He looked at her and felt like crying. Because at some point he’d realized he was wrong. And when Purple Smile looked at him and offered him a mug of ale, Yellow Splatters searched for the pain and anxiety and anger in his chest and realized it was gone.

The music had taken it away.

The party in the inn had music, people, food, and more importantly, a *need*. After so many days of tension and anxiety, all of that emotion had to go one way. And so Erin took it and released it. She filled her inn with music and people heard.

“I heard an odd sound. What is going on? Oh. Hello Ksmvr, other Antinium I do not know. Are you having a good day? Good. I am Bird.”

The Antinium on the roof came down, swept up by the music. He found himself shouting at Badarrow about arrows as the Goblin admired his bow. Bird quite enjoyed that. He kept waving his arms and shouting over the music.

“You shot me! It was a good shot! I said *good shot!* Show me how!”

That was the first. Then a Worker took a wrong turn going to the bathroom and Octavia poked her head into the inn, looking outraged.

“Hey, what’s all that noise? I’m trying to wor—hey, what’s this music?”

She came in. And she was the last. No one would come to an inn with Goblins, after all. No matter what they heard.

A group of Drake and Gnoll [Guardsmen], or rather [Guardspeople] since there were [Guardswomen] among them as well, was patrolling around Liscor, searching for monster nests and so on. They heard the music echoing from the inn on their way back.

“Hey, that’s a good song.”

One of the Drakes looked up as she heard the beat coming from the inn. Another Drake leaned on his spear and sighed.

“Huh. That’s loud.”

The other [Guardsmen] looked at each other. One coughed.

“There’s Goblins at that inn now.”

The others nodded.

“Yeah.”

“Damn Goblins.”

“Can’t imagine what that innkeeper’s thinking.”

“Eh. She was always crazy. Remember that time she was singing and there was all that music? Good food. Dancing...”

“Yeah. Shame she has all those Goblins there.”

“Yeah.”

The [Guardspeople] stared towards the inn, where the music was flooding the wet landscape. On this grey day, it was as if someone had taken the sun and brought it inside. It was as if the light was music and it was flooding out of the inn. One of the Drakes sighed.

“Damn lucky Goblins.”

“Good night! Good night to you all! Don’t get lost on your way back! And don’t fight with each other anymore, okay? Or I’ll come over and kick both your butts!”

Erin said goodbye to the Antinium just before midnight. Her voice was raw and her legs hurt. She wasn’t the only one.

The Goblins had passed out downstairs. Numbtongue, true to his name and past, had practically lost his voice. He could actually sing! And he had taken the guitar. Ishkr had signed off with a hefty overtime bonus, complaining his claws hurt. But he had been smiling.

As for the others? The Halfseekers went to sleep tired, but beaming. None of them had danced with the Goblins, but as they had found there was

room in the inn for both of them. The Horns of Hammerad had passed out in their room already. And Mrsha was in her room with Lyonette.

Healing. It was a long process. But if Erin was good at one thing, it was bridging gaps. Between people, in hearts... Yellow Splatters walked slowly back with Purple Smile and thought about all the mistakes he'd made.

Because he'd been wrong. The Antinium needed Erin Solstice more than they needed him. They didn't need more training. They needed to stare at the sky.

And he had forgotten that. Because...because he'd seen too many of his people. Because he'd forgotten what had made him Individual to begin with. Because he was a fool.

And that knowledge left him quiet and empty. Despair over Twin Stripes crushed him. His failures hung about him. If the music and food had not filled him with hope and happiness, Yellow Splatters might have been lost. As it was, he was simply sad.

He reported back to his barracks and sat for a long time by himself. The other Soldiers had brought gifts for the others. Food from Erin's inn—still fresh—one of Mrsha's balls she'd given them to throw around, and even a small keg. The Soldiers mainly just stared at that since they'd forgotten to bring bowls.

As for Yellow Splatters? He looked at Purple Smile and thought the other Soldier would be a good [Sergeant]. And he wondered if he could be one as well. He looked around the barracks, at the sparring area, and then at a space that had never really been used.

A few pieces of carefully-bound paper sat in a corner. Just ink and paper. But Pawn had seen the value in them. Yellow Splatters went over, and, with many Soldiers watching him furtively, sat down and picked up a book clumsily.

It was very hard to turn the pages, and the lighting wasn't good. When Yellow Splatters got the first page open he saw there was a Drake child on the page. A Drake child with a magic sword.

He had no name. The book had no words. It was just pictures. But there was a story there. Yellow Splatters read the book slowly, turning the pages laboriously, but caught up in the little Drake's story.

He had a sword. A magic sword, surely, because when he found it, it glowed. And it slew a Mothbear, a Wyvern, a horde of undead, and then it carried him into the sky to fight a Giant on a mountain. The Drake became a hero. He had friends. He led an army. And then they crowned him as he sat in a city he had built.

It was a simple story. A simple story for a child, with no real moral other than that magic swords were amazing, and that slaying monsters was good. But it was the first one Yellow Splatters had ever read. And it was magic.

When the Soldier looked up from the book, he found he was not alone. Someone sat across from him. Pawn. The Worker looked tired, but smiled as Yellow Splatters froze and looked at him.

"I did not want to disturb you from your reading. Forgive me. I did not see you at the front as usual so I grew worried."

The front? But that was in—Yellow Splatters checked his internal clock and realized it was long past dawn. Morning, in fact. He'd read the book for—he shot to his feet in a sudden panic. The fighting! The *monsters!*

He'd abandoned his post. He would have run towards the front had Pawn not caught him.

"Be calm, Yellow Splatters. There is no need for fighting today. Hopefully...not tomorrow or much at all."

What? Yellow Splatters stared at Pawn uncomprehendingly. The Worker nodded.

“It will be easier to show you. Come.”

He took the [Sergeant] down the tunnels, past groups of Soldiers who were not marching to their deaths but rather wandering around, looking confused. Yellow Splatters arrived at the place where they normally fought and found something else in its place.

A barricade of stone and dirt. High walls—intersecting tunnels filled with disguised pits stuffed with spikes, tunnels designed to collapse once triggered. And wide areas designed to funnel monsters so they would kill each other. Belgrade was explaining all of this at length to Klbkch and Purple Smile when Yellow Splatters arrived.

“You see, it takes advantage of the dungeon’s radius. Monsters will pass by this point and into this room and begin to attack each other. We have set it up so monsters will arrive at roughly the same time. After they have reduced each other’s numbers, we have many, many trapped tunnels which they will be forced to travel through. And if they survive that—”

“A kill zone.”

Klbkch studied the final room, in which rows of Workers stood. Workers, not Soldiers. There were Soldiers at the ready, but they had yet to fight today. Instead, the Workers were armed with the Antinium’s crude bows and arrows. They stood behind battlements that had been constructed to let them fire behind shelter, and they had slaughtered the few monsters that had made it to their position with massed volleys. Belgrade nodded proudly.

“Pawn has long said this and both Anand and I agree. It is time for Workers to take charge of defending the Hive as much as Soldiers do. Moreover, we *need* an archery-based unit. Thus, we have found those

Individual and regular Workers who seem to have an aptitude for aiming and equipped them. You will note in the budget report I sent that I am requesting better bows and arrows.”

The Revalantor flicked through several pages of parchment and nodded.

“I see. And your prediction?”

“Over 86% reduction in casualties taken and a greatly reduced need for constant combat. True, the material costs rise by a small margin, but this would allow our Hive to allocate resources and bodies—”

“Yes. I see. Am I to understand this was your undertaking, Belgrade?”

Yellow Splatters stared at the [Tactician]. Belgrade nodded as Anand walked over, munching on an apple. Purple Smile must have offered it to him.

“That is correct, Revalantor Klbkch. Recently, my acquired Skills have shifted in nature. Both Anand and I have received Skills, but while his pertain to rapid movement and assaults, I have obtained Skills suitable for static defenses. My two latest Skills—obtained from reaching Level 20—are [Simple Trap Construction] and [Basic Fortification Construction].”

“Very useful.”

Anand munched down the rest of his apple. Pawn nodded. He stepped forwards as Klbkch turned to him.

“It is a project all of us have worked on tirelessly, Revalantor Klbkch. Were it not for the Painted Soldiers, we would not have been able to hold the areas around the dungeon’s entrance to construct this defensive network.”

Yellow Splatters and Purple Smile turned to Pawn. Realization flashed between the two and Yellow Splatters trembled inside. Klbkch looked

around, clicking his mandibles, seemingly at a loss.

“Very...good. Unexpectedly good. Carry on. I will relay this to the Queen. I do not doubt she will be very...well, good.”

He walked off. The Workers stared at him, and then gathered around to celebrate.

“I think he was impressed.”

“I owe it all to Erin. And you, Pawn. And you, Anand.”

Belgrade seemed overjoyed, his antennae trembling with emotion. He spoke, fondling a chess piece on the command table as he did.

“It is as Erin said, every time I despaired of beating you in chess, Anand. Practice can defeat talent. And when I applied that to the real world—preparation and planning will win battles in advance of reactionary tactics. I may not have your gift Anand, but I can contribute to the Hive in my own way.”

“I did not doubt it for a second, Belgrade.”

Anand grasped Belgrade’s shoulder, speaking softly. He indicated the maze of defenses.

“This is beyond me. This is your accomplishment. And the scope of it—you have won battles before I needed to fight them. I believe this understanding is key to what it means to be a [Strategist], and not simply a [Tactician]. That is why you will reach that class first, Belgrade. Be proud of what you have done.”

The Worker quivered in place. Anand hesitated, and then embraced him. The two Workers hugged as the other Antinium looked on. After a second, Belgrade spoke in a more normal voice.

“While I appreciate the gesture and am very emotional, Anand, I do not seem to have acquired the ‘warm and fuzzy’ feelings that Erin spoke of.”

Anand let go and nodded.

“Neither do I. Perhaps it is an error in our methods? Our expertise?”

“Let us ask her when we next meet.”

“Yes. For now...I think we have earned a break. Pawn, we shall be sleeping now. You know how to manage the defenses—”

“And I will wake you if needed. Rest, you two. You deserve it.”

Pawn let the two Workers stagger off, and then turned. The two Soldiers stared at him. Pawn nodded.

“We will need a few Painted Soldiers in case of dangerous enemies, but far fewer than before. You two are relieved of duty for now. We will have to find more ways to occupy you two in the future. More patrols perhaps. Or maybe...books.”

He looked at Yellow Splatters as he said that. The [Sergeant] just stood in place. No more fighting? His people wouldn’t die? He was...what a fool he’d been.

Perhaps Pawn sensed it, because he put a hand on Yellow Splatters’ shoulder. And surprisingly, so did Purple Smile.

“I know what you have been going through, Yellow Splatters. And some of the fault is ours. We did not want to speak of what we were doing, should we fail. But we should have told you. As for the rest...I am glad.”

Glad? Yellow Splatters looked at Pawn in astonishment. After all he’d done, after *what* he’d done. Perhaps it could be forgiven. But Twin Stripes? Never.

Again, Pawn read his mind.

“Come with me. I have one last thing to show you. And this is my accomplishment.”

He led the two Soldiers away, through tunnels, to a new area. A small room had been hollowed out and a door installed. Two Soldiers stood aside as the Worker opened the door. Yellow Splatters froze as he saw Twin Stripes chained to the ground.

“Ah.”

The Aberration Soldier was thrashing. Pawn bowed his head and stepped forwards, but both Yellow Splatters and Purple Smile moved forwards protectively. Twin Stripes was trying to move, trying to get at Yellow Splatters. The [Sergeant] wanted to let him.

But it was Pawn who moved. The Worker walked forwards, heedless of the Aberration struggling in his manacles. He bent, and raised something.

A hand. And in it he held light. Or...was light drawn to his hand? He reached out, and Twin Stripes froze as it touched his head gently.

Two more hands rose. Pawn's other hands reached out and touched Purple Smile on the chest, and Yellow Splatters on the arm. The Worker's mandibles opened and he uttered a word.

“Hope.”

It was the simplest of messages. A quiet word, breathed into the silence, spoken with all the sincerity in the world. And with it came forgiveness, peace.

A blessing.

Yellow Splatters jerked, feeling warmth and light entering him. Twin Stripes stopped thrashing and Purple Smile touched his chest as Pawn

withdrew his hands. The Worker bent over Twin Stripes and the Soldier looked up. The Soldier, not the Aberration.

“This is my gift. Three times per day I may use [Benediction of Hope] to ease those in need. I think it calms the thoughts. It gives our people hope, a small blessing. And perhaps—understanding. Of what it means to be Individual.”

Yellow Splatters looked at Pawn. He was shaking. He should have been exhausted after being up for over a day. But now he felt fresh. And the despair that had gripped him, the pain and guilt—it was still there. But something else was in him, balancing it out.

Hope.

And he looked down at Twin Stripes and knew the Soldier was back. Slowly, Yellow Splatters bent and freed the Soldier. Twin Stripes got up slowly, and Yellow Splatters bowed his head. The two were silent for a moment before Purple Smile seized both of them up in a hug. The Soldiers struggled, and then went limp. It was not warm and fuzzy at all. But it was...perfect.

Pawn looked at the Soldiers and smiled. He bowed his head.

“Congratulations, [Sergeant] Purple Smile. I think you and Yellow Splatters will be a wonderful team.”

Yellow Splatters looked at Purple Smile as the other Antinium let go. Purple Smile tilted his head to look at Yellow Splatters, and the [Sergeant] saw the weight of command settle on his shoulders. But that was the thing about Purple Smile. He just brushed the weight off.

And that was the word for it. At last, Yellow Splatters realized what was missing. He looked around. Not a leader. Not alone. That wasn't what he

was. At last, he knew. He was one of many. Not the lone leader. He could rely on others.

He had a team. A people. A mission.

A family.

One last thing. In the Wandering Inn, as Erin went back to her kitchen to snore and Lyonette lay in her bed, sleeping in a quieter manner, a small Gnoll sat in her room and listened. She heard only silence.

She had had a big day and she was tired. She had been angry, sad, happy...Mrsha knew she was still in trouble and she still had a lot of being sorry to do. But the music had helped. The food had helped. And Erin...

The words were still in her. She did not have to forgive. And she hadn't. Mrsha had been afraid, so afraid when she'd gone downstairs. But the Selphid had leaned down and whispered to her, and Moore had smiled and given her a bud that bloomed into a flower in her hands. Mrsha had felt safe with them.

She did not forgive the Goblins. But she had sat in the inn and watched them all day. Not all people were the same. And yet, Mrsha couldn't forget it was their people who had slaughtered her tribe.

Each time one of them laughed, Mrsha hated all of the Goblins and their entire species. When they smiled, she wished their happiness would go away. It was easy to hate them, then.

It was harder, much harder, to hate them when they cried. When they shed a tear for a sad song that made Mrsha curl up inside, or when they

hugged each other and looked around as if they expected there to be others with them. Then it was hard.

Mrsha had gone upstairs, but she could still smell them in the basement. Sleeping. She could even smell they were sleeping. Their scents were one of many in the inn. Only, she'd been focused on them for so long she had forgotten the other ones. Now she could smell Lyonette next to her, comforting, and Pisces in another room, playing with dead bones. And Yvlon—still smelling of fire and burning.

The Goblins were below. Mrsha knew that. She still hated them. And maybe she always would. But she stopped waiting for the moment when they would draw their swords and kill her. Mrsha curled up into a ball and slept.

At some point, Apista crawled out from a mug downstairs and looked around. She had miraculously survived the raucous party simply by the expedient of hiding in the mug and scaring the daylights out of anyone who reached for a drink. She fanned her wings and flew up to the ceiling, where she perched by a windowsill and fanned her wings in the warm sun.

Everyone was sleeping, of course. Partying did that to people. As for insects, well, their opinions were less well recorded on the matter. Apista consumed a bit of nectar from the faerie flowers. She might not be a person. But she was happy.

4.43

“I’m going into the city now. Do you want to come or stay?”

The next day, Lyonette was sitting in front of Mrsha, talking to her. The small white Gnoll was chewing on the tip of her wand and looked up curiously at her. Lyonette went on.

“The Horns of Hammerad are resting. Ceria got bit badly on the leg and butt yesterday and no one wants to do much after the party, so the Halfseekers might be here all day too. You can stay with them or come with me. Which is it?”

Mrsha rolled backwards and then slumped onto her side, accidentally jabbing the inside of her mouth with the tip of the wand. She yelped and Lyonette sighed.

“I told you not to play with that! Give it here, Mrsha. You can’t keep—”

The Gnoll scuttled away from Lyonette, holding her wand possessively. She glanced at Lyonette and after a moment, shook her head and pointed to the floor.

“You want to stay here? You’re sure?”

Mrsha hesitated. But then she nodded. Lyonette smiled a bit.

Progress. After yesterday, it seemed like she could leave the inn without Mrsha coming with her. The Gnoll seemed secure if she was around the adventurers, especially Jelaqua and Moore who doted on her. It felt like all the anxiety and stress everyone had been under was a memory of months ago, rather than yesterday. Lyonette was grateful for that beyond words.

But there were still things she had to put her foot down on. She and Mrsha had done a lot of reconciling since yesterday, but one thing had to

change.

“No more wand. Come on, give it here.”

She held out her hand. Mrsha clutched the magical artifact worth hundreds or thousands of gold pieces to her chest and shook her head rapidly. Lyonette sighed.

“Mrsha, I know you like biting it. But it doesn’t bother you where that wand has been?”

The Gnoll paused as she put the tip into her mouth and stared at Lyonette. Clearly, soap and water cured all ills in her book. She shook her head and darted back as Lyonette tried to grab the wand.

“I’m sorry, but you’re still not keeping it! Come here, missy!”

A short chase and struggle later, Mrsha was reaching for the wand and making unhappy sounds as Lyonette walked downstairs. She walked over to a table where the Horns of Hammerad were relaxing in good spirits and plonked down the wand in front of a surprised Pisces.

“Here. Your wand. Please don’t let Mrsha take it again.”

Pisces stared askance at the wand which was wet with drool. He picked it up gingerly with two fingers and stared at Mrsha. The Gnoll stared back.

It had become either a game or a contest between the two over possession of the wand. Pisces would keep it every time Lyonette managed to wrest it out of Mrsha’s paws, and the Gnoll would try everything in her power to steal it back. She’d hide under tables, try sneaking into his room at night—her latest trick had involved ambushing Pisces right as he left the outhouse.

The game amused Mrsha and Pisces, but not Lyonette. She glared at the [Mage]. He smiled at her.

“I shall endeavor to keep it out of young Mrsha’s possession, Miss Lyonette.”

“Don’t endeavor. *Try.*”

She turned away before Pisces could tell her that was what he’d said. He couldn’t ruin her good spirits. She found another group sitting at a table and gingerly approached.

“Miss Jelaqua?”

“Kill me.”

The Selphid was draped over the table, groaning audibly. She winced as Mrsha hopped onto the table and patted her head. Jelaqua sat up with a wince as Mrsha pulled a bit at the stitching around her head.

“Don’t pull at that, Mrsha. I’m no Stitch-Woman and if the head comes off, you’re going to see something you won’t like. What’s up, Lyonette?”

“I need someone to look after Mrsha while I go into the city. Erin’s going and Ishkr’s going to be busy, so I was hoping...”

“We can take care of her.”

Behind Jelaqua, a slumped figure sat up. As usual Moore was sitting cross-legged on the ground, there not being a chair large enough for him. He smiled tenderly at Mrsha and she waved one paw at him. Lyonette looked over and a shape in dark clothing groaned at her. Seborn looked more dead than alive, and the crustacean side of his body looked like it was leaking some kind of liquid.

“Mrsha’s fine to stay with us as long as she wants, Lyonette. I don’t think we’re in any condition to do...anything.”

Jelaqua informed the [Barmaid] as she winced herself upright. She was clearly feeling the effects of heavy drinking last night. She looked longingly

towards the door to Celum.

“We won’t go far, although we might go to Octavia’s shop and see if she sells any hangover potions. Otherwise I think Seborn will shank himself to end the misery.”

“Don’t tempt me.”

Lyonette grinned as Seborn looked up. Drowned Man he might be, but Seborn drank like a sailor, at a pace only matched by Jelaqua’s enthusiasm and Moore’s capacity for alcohol.

Very quietly thanking the Halfseekers, Lyonette walked stealthily away from them and towards the kitchen. She was nearly there when she heard a terrific *crash* of falling pots and pans. She looked over her shoulder just in time to see Seborn *twitch* and Jelaqua’s eyes roll back into her head for a moment.

“Oops, sorry!”

Erin cheerfully poked her head out of the kitchen and waved at two of the Goblins sitting at a table who’d looked up. Headscratcher and Shorthilt looked at the smiling young woman and then went back to sharpening their swords with a grunt. Lyonette passed by them, staring as they carefully maintained their well-worn steel blades.

This was how things were better. Lyonette didn’t guiltily look away when Headscratcher noticed she was looking. She just smiled politely and the Goblin tried to do the same. There was still a strong sense of...of distance between her and the Goblins, but the fear had mostly gone.

The inn felt better. It truly did. And as Lyonette walked into the kitchen, she saw Erin was smiling for the first time in what felt like weeks. She was masterminding a grand operation with a harried Ishkr, and by the looks of it, she was generating enough dirty dishes to keep the Gnoll busy all day.

“Okay, frosting’s done! And the batter is good—I’m sticking it in the oven now, Ishkr. You’re sure you can take it out after thirty minutes or when it looks done? Remember what I told you about sticking a fork in?”

The Gnoll [Waiter] nodded, licking a bit of frosted white sugar off the hair on his arms.

“I will not forget, Miss Erin. And I can smell when cooked food begins to burn.”

“Awesome. Okay Lyonette, I think I’m ready! Is Mrsha coming or staying?”

“Staying. I think she’s tired from yesterday.”

Lyonette smiled as Erin took off her apron and the two young women walked out of the inn. Erin waved at the Horns of Hammerad, pausing only long enough to ask where Ksmvr and Yvlon were. Both Ceria and Pisces pointed, and the two Human girls found the [Warriors] outside, sparring.

Ksmvr was dodging back and forth while Yvlon struck at him with a crude wooden practice sword. He had two wooden swords as well, and both were wearing what armor they possessed. As Erin and Lyonette watched, he leapt up into the air, incredibly high.

“Whoa!”

Erin shouted in amazement. The Ring of Jumping let Ksmvr soar upwards. Erin and Lyonette heard a voice from above.

“Oh. Hello Ksmvr. How are you d—”

Bird didn’t get a chance to finish. The Antinium landed behind Yvlon and lashed out. But she, forewarned by the jump, was already stepping forwards. She poked Ksmvr in the chest and he raised his swords.

“I have died again.”

“Stop saying that. I keep telling you, it’s ‘lost’. And you did well. If you could just jump less high, I wouldn’t have time to react. As it is, you’re a target.”

“I agree. Unfortunately, I miscalculated. I had intended to land on your head.”

“Please don’t do that. My helmet might not survive the impact. My head definitely won’t.”

The two disappeared as Erin and Lyonette walked down the hill. Both girls had to work hard not to slip in the slushy snow. Erin wobbled as she walked in her thick winter boots.

“Whoa! Slippery. It’s really getting warmer, isn’t it? Only, there’s so much snow that it’s still not melting.”

“True. It’ll probably be a week or two before it melts. But I can feel a layer of water underneath now. And if I walk into some of the valleys, I’ll be waist-deep in water and drenched before I blink.”

Lyonette made a face as she walked. Erin nodded.

“Yeah. According to Olesm, it’ll get worse when it starts to rain. I can’t imagine what that’s like. I guess you won’t be harvesting any more honey, right? I mean, putting them to sleep is one thing, but the snow’s your emergency fallback. I don’t think I’d be okay with you not having a way to get away if the faerie flowers don’t work.”

“Maybe. I was thinking there might be another way to distract the bees in case something bad happens. A distraction—something Octavia might have. I’m going to ask her about it, if you’re okay with me spending some gold.”

“Sure. Ashfire Bee honey makes us a lot of money. Just don’t let her sell you any other potions while you’re at it.”

Their conversation was light, revolving around business and life in general. And that was what they wanted. In these days when it seemed like every two seconds there was another report about the Goblin Lord burning a village or marching here or there...this is what they wanted.

Peace. At least for a day. So Erin and Lyonette walked into Liscor and did normal things. The first thing they did was visit Krshia.

They hadn't been sure that the Gnoll [Shopkeeper] would be at her stall today. She had been absent since Brunkr's death. And while Erin had visited the Gnoll in her apartment, it was a relief to see her at her small stall like usual.

"Erin! Lyonette. It is good to see you two, yes?"

The Gnoll turned with a jar of ointment in her hands. The two Humans waited patiently while Krshia closed her deal—selling an ointment for dry scales to a harried Drake woman. Then they had time to talk.

Was it a sign of how Krshia's fortunes had changed that she was stuck on the edges of the market, in a far smaller stall than the one she'd used to have? Then again, it could be argued that her enduring business was a sign that her popularity among customers hadn't waned.

It still hurt Lyonette to see the stall and remember what she'd done. But Krshia and Erin acted as if there was nothing to remember. They chatted happily, not giving voice to darker memories. It was something everyone there understood. The voices that whispered and the images that rose unbidden at night and in quiet times would come regardless of happiness in the day. They clung to better moments like sailors adrift at sea.

“I did not think to see you without young Mrsha today. But then, I have heard that you reached an understanding of sorts yesterday with the... Goblins.”

Krshia sniffed at Lyonette, and the girl was reminded that Gnoll noses, like Gnoll hearing, picked up far more than their owners usually let on. Erin smiled teasingly.

“You just happened to hear it from Ishkr?”

“Hrm. He *is* a distant nephew and a dutiful one. But many heard it themselves. The music your inn played was audible to many [Guardsmen] on the walls. Several complained about missing the fun as they saw it, yes?”

Erin laughed.

“If they wanted to have fun, they could have come! The Goblins aren’t dangerous.”

“So you say. But I am afraid it will take more than your words to bring others into your inn. For me as well, I regret to tell you.”

“Really?”

The Gnoll smiled gently at Erin’s crestfallen look.

“Memory runs deep, Erin Solstice. This city and this continent still remember the Goblin King and what he did. But I will trust you, even if I will not visit for now. Now tell me, why are you here? To chat, or buy as well?”

“Oh! Well, we could use more sugar. And eggs. And meat—everyone eats a lot of that and I want to make a hotpot. Of course, we could use a lot of alcohol—a few kegs, actually. I know the Street Runner can’t carry that many, so maybe you could let us know when we should come and pick them up? Ishkr and Bird can do it since...I don’t want to. And I’d like to

order some pottery bowls the Soldiers could use. I was thinking they could be bigger and easier to hold...”

Erin ran down a very long and rambling list of items as Krshia nodded and scratched at a piece of parchment with some charcoal. She probably had around a tenth of the items Erin was requesting in her shop at best, but she knew everyone who sold what Erin wanted, and would talk to them and get it all sent to Erin’s inn for the young woman.

It was an interesting system that Lyonette hadn’t experienced in Terandria. But as Erin had remarked, it was worth however many coins Krshia charged to have the Gnoll do her shopping for her. In fact, that was one of Krshia’s main sources of income—she was the Gnoll a lot of her customers went to in order to avoid hours of shopping.

“Hmm. Costly this time. I will have it all ready for you by tomorrow at the latest. Give me...hrr. Yes, six gold coins for all of it. The pottery being custom-made will be expensive. But I may be able to talk the [Potter] down. I will let you know.”

Erin handed over the gold coins and Krshia swept them into a small bag. She glanced up at Erin, and then looked sideways at Lyonette.

“I have a thought. Lyonette, if you are willing, would you come to my apartment after I close my stall for the day? I will only be open for another hour or so; I have many orders like Erin’s to begin filling. I would like to chat for a few minutes if I may.”

“Of course.”

Lyonette exchanged a surprised glance with Erin. She made plans to meet with Krshia and the two said their goodbyes. As they walked away, Lyonette leaned over to Erin at the same time the other girl was doing the same. They nearly knocked heads.

“What was *that* about, Lyonette? I didn’t know that Krshia liked you enough to invite you into her apartment.”

“I have no idea, Erin! I know she forgave me a bit, but—what should I do?”

“Dunno. Just go and see what she wants I guess. Oh, and eat lots of the raw meat. It’s good and also, polite.”

“R-raw meat? Do I have to...?”

The two young women walked on. They had things to do, or rather, not do. It wasn’t that Erin was a huge fan of shopping in general; she had better things to do than spend her money on personal expenses like clothing and so on, especially when she had her inn to think about. But window-shopping was relaxing, as was finding which [Merchants] had come with expensive and rare magical artifacts to sell.

“Ooh! A magic ball that runs away when you chase it!”

Erin admired a minor artifact that was attracting a lot of children. She thought Mrsha would love it—although the price tag was far more than she was willing to pay. A few dogs were also trying to go after the ball, but the [Merchant] who owned the object was determined to protect his wares, lest dog drool drive down the price.

“It’s so weird seeing a Gnoll owning a dog.”

“Why? I’ve seen Cat-Tribe Beastkin who have their own cats. They’re just animals. Plus, I hear Gnolls and Beastkin make great pet owners since they establish themselves as pack leaders easily.”

Lyonette looked at a Gnoll who was indeed leading a large mastiff around with ease. The Gnoll growled at the dog as it tried to run after the ball and the dog froze, whining a bit. Erin noted the lack of a leash.

“That’s cool. But don’t Gnolls also eat dogs?”

“Well...so do Humans. And it’s not all of them. Just a few tribes and some Humans. Honestly, I’d be more worried about Ceria. I know for a fact that half-Elves will eat dogs.”

The Gnoll dog-owner looked at Lyonette and Erin, horrified, and hurried her dog away as if she was afraid they would break out the forks and plates right then and there. Guiltily, Erin and Lyonette walked away.

Life was good. Tranquil. Placid, even. Both girls weren’t exactly waiting for the ball to drop, but when it did, they weren’t surprised. They were just about to split up for Erin to go visit Klbkch and Lyonette to see Krshia when they heard someone shouting at them.

“You there! Human!”

It was a vaguely familiar voice. Erin turned around, frowning, and saw a Drake wearing fancy clothing striding towards them with a small host of Drakes following behind. A few things struck her at once.

The first was that she’d seen him before, although her memory was a bit fuzzy. The second was that this Drake was rich. He had fancy clothes on, and a number of sparkling rings on his claws that were clearly magical. And lastly, he was drunk. The Drake was walking well, but there was a certain unsteadiness in his steps that told her he was some degree of sloshed, and early in the morning as well.

“Can I help you?”

The Drake stumbled as he approached Erin and she took a step back. He looked at her, slightly unfocused. He reeked of drink and looked...well, Erin had seen Relc on a bad day with his scales flaking off, bloodshot eyes, and reeking of sweat and grime. This Drake was pretty much all those

things except richer, which meant he'd covered up the smells with cologne and his clothes were new at least.

"You're that Human. The one who owns the inn."

He looked at her and Erin recognized him at last. Wall Lord Ilvriss was hard to recognize without his armor and in his disheveled state. But he still managed to sneer at her and project quite a bit of arrogance into his tone.

"Human. I have business with you."

"My name is Erin Solstice. And I remember you. You're the lord-guy who was with Zel. You ran into my inn with Olesm two days ago, right after him! You knocked over two tables and nearly stepped on Mrsha's tail!"

Erin put her hands on her hips and glared as the rest of Ilvriss' escort caught up. She spotted Olesm hovering at the back of the group of important-looking Drakes. She waved at him.

Ilvriss sniffed. He glared at Lyonette.

"I am Wall Lord Ilvriss, [Innkeeper]. I have confidential business I wish to discuss with you. Your employee may leave."

It was ironic, Lyonette thought, that she was on the receiving end of the treatment she'd used to give Erin and other people. She glanced at Erin and the young woman made a face.

"If you want to go, Lyonette, I'll handle Wall-Face over here. It might take a while so meet me back at the inn when you're done."

"Okay."

Lyonette backed away, half-wanting to stay as Ilvriss narrowed his eyes at Erin. The young woman turned back to face him, frowning.

"So what do you want? Hey, didn't I throw a pan at your head once?"

The Drake blinked, and then frowned at Erin.

“Yes. I recall. You should consider yourself fortunate that at the time I had not activated my rings for battle. You are equally fortunate I overlooked that transgression. Now—”

“Wait, your rings? How would that help?”

There was a muted gasp of collective outrage from behind Ilvriss as Erin interrupted the Wall Lord. She didn’t care; she was enjoying herself. From Olesm’s face, he was equally horrified and amused.

Ilvriss paused. He was clearly drunk *and* hung over, and thus behind even Seborn in terms of mental acuity at the moment. He stared, irritated, at Erin and raised his hand slowly. Two fat rings, one made of ruby, the other sporting a large topaz in the center, glinted at her.

“I am a *Lord of the Wall*, one of the Drake nobility, you ignorant Human—I am naturally equipped with many magical items that ensure my safety. But my attire is not why I wanted to speak to—”

“Oh yeah? What does that one do?”

Enjoying herself now, Erin pointed to one of the rings. Ilvriss blinked.

“That ring sets my scales aflame with magical fire. Stop interrupting. I —”

“And what about that one? The shiny yellow gem one?”

“A projectile shield. Would you—”

“And that?”

“Strength enchantments. Wait—stop asking questions!”

The scales around Ilvriss’ face grew redder, and Erin saw his escort shifting their feet and twitching their tails. She heard a strangled noise and

saw Olesm trying valiantly not to burst out laughing. He was having chest convulsions trying to hold it in.

Ilvriss glared around and massaged his temples, seeming to wake up a bit more. He growled and stepped closer to Erin. She stepped back to avoid the fumes of his breath.

“You stink. Have you been drinking? It’s not healthy, you know.”

“I don’t—stop talking—I came here to—”

“I should know. I’m an [Innkeeper].”

“*Shut up!*”

Ilvriss finally roared at Erin, and she did shut up, if only to wipe the spit off her face. The Wall Lord breathed heavily for a few seconds, and then straightened.

“I came here to discuss a mutually profitable arrangement, Human. You need not speak—no, be *quiet!* Simply listen. You are in possession of a powerful magical door that is enchanted with the [Teleport] spell.”

“Yup.”

Erin smiled as she nettled the Wall Lord. She didn’t exactly dislike him—she thought he was a rude jerk, but he had helped her before and she mainly just enjoyed annoying him. Ilvriss purpled a bit, but he went on slowly.

“I understand your magical door connects to the Human city of Celum, a hundred miles north of here. I wonder if it could be attuned to another location?”

“You mean, another city? Sure. I was planning on getting it to link to Invrissil, but then there was that Goblin Lord business...why, do you want to take a trip somewhere?”

Ilvriss nodded, and several of his adjutants murmured as he straightened.

“I am in need of rapid transportation, Human. Obviously I am reluctant to ask your ki—I would like to make a trip to my home city of Salazsar at all speed. How quickly can you connect your door to that location?”

Erin blinked at the Wall Lord.

“Salazsar? Oh...that’s one of the Walled Cities, right?”

She’d assumed nothing could make Ilvriss more irate, but that off-hand remark seemed to drive his annoyance with her to another level. He opened his mouth, closed it, and then replied as his tail thrashed the ground angrily.

“Salazsar is the *premier* Walled City, the hub of Drake civilization and an icon of the continent you ignorant—ape!”

“Fine. No need to be rude about it. Okay, how far away is it?”

Her cavalier attitude seemed to be stumping Ilvriss. He paused.

“Does that matter?”

Erin nodded.

“Yeah. You see, my door can only go as far as Invrissil in terms of distance and even then, it’d only be able to transport one person at a time and it would take a day to recharge each time.”

The news elicited a groan from the Drakes behind Ilvriss. The Wall Lord frowned.

“Really? Is there no way of improving upon the enchantment?”

“Nope. At least, Typhenous and Pisces didn’t think so. I could probably recharge it faster if I had mana stones, but that doesn’t mean I can make it go further.”

Ilvriss glanced over his shoulder at one of his aides. The female Drake was doing calculations on an abacus, which intrigued Erin. She glanced up at the Wall Lord and nodded.

“That would save us at least a week of travelling, Wall Lord, not to mention the dangers of the journey.”

“Very well.”

He grunted and turned back to Erin.

“If the limit of your door is to Invrissil...that puts it at around four hundred miles...then I request it be linked to Pallass. That is a Walled City, Human.”

“I knew that! I think. And I’d be okay with that, Mr. Rude Drake, but I can’t do it just like that.”

Erin glared at Ilvriss. He glared back.

“Why *not*?”

“Because...I need to put an anchor at the place I want to go before my door can connect to it. So, sorry, but until I get someone to run all the way to Pallass or Invrissil, I can’t make the door connect anywhere else. I was going to get a Courier to do it, but then the Goblin Lord appeared and...”

Erin shrugged helplessly. Ilvriss rubbed at his face and growled.

“Ancestors preserve me. The door needs an anchor? Very well, I will employ the Courier in this city to take whatever this...anchor is. I assume it is not heavy, or at least portable via a bag of holding?”

“Oh, it’s really small. But I already asked Hawk and he said—”

“I don’t *care* what he said! He will begin his journey this day on *my* orders, threat of Goblins or not! I am a Lord of the Wall, not some

[Innkeeper] with a few gold coins!”

Ilvriss snapped at Erin. She raised her hands.

“Well excuse *me*. It’s just my door that you want to use. What if I said no?”

By now their discussion had attracted a few people who were watching with interest. Ilvriss’ jaw worked silently as he glared at Erin.

“You are in no position to refuse—”

“My inn, my rules. I’ll let you use the door *if* you ask nicely.”

Erin folded her arms and smirked. Ilvriss looked like he was swallowing his tongue. Olesm was doubled over and clutching at his stomach, much to the concern of the Drakes around him. When Ilvriss did find his voice, it was strangled with the effort of restraining himself.

“I will send one of my people to the building you call an inn. Give them whatever instructions you need. And when the door is connected to Pallass, I expect to be the first person through. If not, I will ensure you regret it.”

There was nothing to really say to that. Erin stuck out her tongue and Ilvriss recoiled as if it were a snake. He took a step back, closed his eyes, and took a deep breath. Then he turned and snapped at his escort.

“Come. We’re returning to the Tailless Thief. At least there the innkeeper knows how to treat people above his station with respect. Swifttail, with me.”

He beckoned and Olesm reluctantly trotted over. The [Tactician] glanced apologetically at Erin as Ilvriss began to walk off. Erin could hear the Wall Lord speaking loudly as he walked.

“I appreciate you not gagging in front of the Human. I understand the reaction, but they do become hard to deal with.”

He clapped Olesm on the shoulder and Erin scowled at Ilvriss' back. She cupped her hands to her mouth and shouted at him.

"Hey! You're a jerk, you know that?"

Her voice, amplified by her [Loud Voice] Skill, echoed down the street. Ilvriss froze mid-step and the people around Erin gaped at her. She looked around and shrugged.

"What? Someone had to tell him."

Ilvriss stormed back down the street, furious. Erin waited until he was close and then spoke.

"You're also drunk and smelly, by the way. You shouldn't wear so much cologne. It stinks."

"I should cut you down for your insolence. Were you in a Walled City, I could have you flogged for your tongue!"

"Really? Well guess what? You're not in one, and unless you want to *walk* the rest of the way back, you'd better be nice to me!"

Erin shot back. Ilvriss rumbled in his chest.

"I could confiscate that door—"

"Try it! If you do, I'll hit you with another pan, you jerk! And I have Gold-rank adventurers in my inn! *And* evil Goblins! Lots of them! You won't take my door alive! I'll help you, but only because I don't want you around, got that?"

Erin shouted back at the Wall Lord. He looked ready to throttle her, and Olesm and another Drake had to hold Ilvriss back. She grinned at him, and privately thought she'd pushed her luck as far as she could. Erin turned.

"Smell you later!"

“Don’t walk away from me! I am a *Lord of the Wall*! You do not leave without my consent!”

Ilvriss roared at her back. Erin turned and stuck her tongue out again.

“Oh yeah? Watch me!”

She began to walk away, faster this time. Ilvriss tore himself loose from his escort and charged after her.

“You do not walk away from a Lord of the Wall. I depart, and you wait. Stop, I command you!”

There was something incredibly sad about the way he tried to bar Erin’s path. She danced around him and he blocked her. And then Ilvriss pointed.

“I said *stop*.”

He used a Skill. It had to be one, because his aides, the people on the street, and Erin’s own feet immediately halted in place. She froze, and felt Ilvriss’ command holding her still. It lasted for all of two seconds, until Erin got mad.

“You don’t order me around!”

She felt a flicker in her chest, a...feeling. It was like when she’d used her own [Inn’s Aura] Skill, or resisted Magnolia’s charmed voice. Erin reached inside herself and *pushed* back. It was very hard, but she began to move her feet. Ilvriss gaped at her as Erin laboriously began to walk again.

“How are you—stop! I command you!”

He pushed again, but Erin was ready and pushed back. Her feet kept moving and Erin began running away. It was *very* hard to resist Ilvriss’ command and she decided she’d had enough. Time to go back to the inn. Unfortunately, Ilvriss didn’t know when to quit.

“Halt! I will not be disobeyed!”

The street was frozen as the Wall Lord chased after the Human girl. She ran, making rude gestures at Ilvriss as he unsteadily staggered and shouted at her. Olesm, halted in mid-stride, could only stare at Ilvriss’ back as the two disappeared down the street. It was over a minute before his limbs could move again.

On the whole, he reflected, that had not been one of Ilvriss’ finest moments. But he also had to admit, it had been incredibly funny. Olesm giggled to himself as Ilvriss’ aides debated going after him in hushed voices. He was in a good mood today. Or maybe he’d just had too much to drink already.

It was probably the latter.

“Why would a Lord of the Wall want to speak with Erin Solstice? It is curious how many famous and powerful people she attracts, is it not?”

Krshia shook her head as she refilled Lyonette’s cup. The Human girl sat tensely in her seat across from the Gnoll and nodded.

“It is. But Erin’s...special. I think she can handle him.”

“True. But I hope whatever he wants does not lead to another incident. Erin Solstice is adept at causing those as well.”

Krshia shook her head as she sipped at her tea. She picked up a cube of meat and popped it into her mouth, and then offered Lyonette the bowl. The girl eyed it and reluctantly took a cube. She bit into it and her face changed.

“This is good!”

“You think so? Truly?”

“Yes! I mean, I don’t eat raw meat because it leads to disease. Not that I’m saying this meat is bad, but us Humans—”

“Yes, I know of your customs.”

Krshia smiled, interrupting Lyonette’s babbling. She nodded at the bowl.

“Be at ease. We Gnolls know how to prepare such food. We ensure it is clean and prepared correctly. You need not have any if you are uncomfortable.”

“No—I’ll have some more.”

Lyonette helped herself to another cube, making Krshia smile. That mattered to the young woman. She shifted.

“I wonder if I could make it. Or take some for Mrsha? I’d like her to have her people’s food to eat. Erin makes great food, but the taste of home...”

“Hmm. It is not good to transport such food, but I could teach you the recipe. And you could bring Mrsha here more often. It would be good to teach her more of our ways. Although she was born to a tribe that lived in the wilderness...she may know more than I do of some things.”

Krshia sipped at her tea and Lyonette nodded. The girl paused as she sipped from her cup. It was hard to forget how she’d been raised—she was acutely aware of her posture and the way she held her teacup. She felt as though she were back in court, sipping tea with nobility. Only, there was no such thing as a Gnoll [Lady]. That was a pity.

How strange life could be. Lyonette looked at Krshia, and remembered the sensation of being grabbed by a huge paw, staring into the Gnoll’s eyes,

and seeing huge fangs as a stall burned behind her. She was ashamed of that. But now she was sitting in said Gnoll's apartment. The same place where her nephew had lived. Where Brunkr had...

Lyonette's eyes moved around the room and Krshia noticed. The [Shopkeeper] lowered her cup.

"There is little of Brunkr here, I am sorry to say. His shield and sword remain, but he arrived here as a warrior, not meaning to stay long. I have only my memories to remind me of what he was."

"Oh. I'm sorry. I was just—"

"I take no offense, Lyonette. Actually, it is that that I wished to talk with you about."

Krshia put down her tea cup and Lyonette felt her heart begin to beat faster. The Gnoll sighed, and in the privacy of her own home, she slumped. She seemed tired, old, and sad all at once. When she looked at Lyonette, there was loss in her brown eyes.

"I still wonder if I could have known. If I had paid more attention, if I had not been blind to that traitorous Regrika Blackpaw's true nature—she is no true Gnoll. And she will be hunted. But if I had only had the foresight to question instead of being blind—would he be alive?"

Lyonette sat still, not knowing what to say. Krshia shook her head.

"These are useless thoughts, of course. What is done is done. Only justice and mourning remain. But I am plagued by them. Yet I would not burden you with my grief, Lyonette. No. I wanted to call you here to thank you, instead."

"Thank me? But why—"

"For making him a [Knight]."

Krshia spoke plainly, and Lyonette's heart constricted with fear. The Gnoll looked at her, not accusingly or with suspicion, rather, with certainty.

"I know you are a [Princess], Lyonette. And I know you gave your blessing to Brunkr to make him a [Knight]."

"How—how do you...?"

The Gnoll snorted.

"I have ears. Brunkr is not good at keeping secrets. As for the rest...it is enough that I know."

Lyonette was frozen in place. Krshia shifted, watching her carefully.

"Mistake me not. I do not seek to profit from this knowledge. I have no other motive than to give my thanks."

"But I didn't do anything."

Lyonette whispered. Krshia shook her head again.

"No. You did much. True, he only had the class for a matter of days. But becoming a [Knight] was Brunkr's dream. It was thought that he would never achieve it, since Gnolls have no [Lords] or other noble classes that could bestow such a class. But you gave it to him, and I must think it made him happy in his last days. For that small gift, I thank you."

She bowed her head and Lyonette burst into tears. For a few minutes there was just her snuffling and Krshia offering her a handkerchief, wiping at her own eyes. Silence. Words unspoken. Lyonette managed a few words after she had finished.

"I don't deserve thanks. All I did—"

"Water."

Krshia raised her hand as if catching raindrops and tossed it away. She sighed.

“You have done much to offend. Much, it is true. But that is the past and you have changed. The debt has been paid, and while I might hold a grudge—no. My nephew’s life is worth more than mere hatred. I forgive, Lyonette. And I thank you for changing. Not least for taking care of Mrsha.”

“What else was I supposed to do?”

Laughing, crying. Krshia smiled and Lyonette grew calmer over time. At last, the two sat, drinking and returning to something like normal conversation. But now the secret was out, Lyonette felt compelled to speak.

“The reason why I ran away—it may seem silly to you, but I really felt like I had to. I was wrong—stupid, arrogant—but if my family knew where I was, I’m sure they’d send someone after me. They might be looking already, but they have no idea where I am and I’m not exactly a First Princess or high-level, so...”

“I understand. I shall say nothing of it if you do not wish me to.”

“Thank you.”

After a while, Krshia spoke again.

“It is curious how you were able to make Brunkr a [Knight], though. He said you spoke only a few words and he gained the class that night. Is it truly so easy?”

Lyonette hesitated. But now was not the time to keep royal secrets. She nodded.

“It’s...well, it’s not supposed to be that simple, you understand. But in practice you can make someone a [Knight] with only a few words. It’s usually a matter of ceremony because it’s so important, but if you’re in a

hurry you can skip all that. At least...I can. I think [Lords] have to work harder at it, you know, have a crest, induct the person into their service, and so on.”

“But a [Princess] is able to do the same more easily? Because your class is superior?”

“Maybe...well, no. I think Mother explained it once. You see, a [Princess] has a different role from a [Lord]. They have their own households, vassals, and so on, so they can support quite a lot of [Knights] depending on how rich and powerful they are. Whereas even a high-level [Princess] has a limit on the amount of [Knights] she can appoint. Mine are personal protectors, you see, so I can choose them quickly and as I please, whereas a [Lord]...”

“Must set up such circumstances. So I see. That is fascinating.”

Krshia nodded. Lyonette smiled and went on.

“It’s a feature of royal classes. Obviously a [King] can appoint a lot more classes, like [King’s Champion], specialized knighthood orders, and so on. I can’t do any of that—the only other thing I can do is royally appoint some business I like.”

Krshia had been chewing at her raw meat. Now she paused and gulped.

“Royally appoint? I am not familiar with this.”

“It’s simple. I can bestow a royal class on someone. Like...say you’re a [Gardener], right? If I want, I could make that person a [Royal Gardener]. Although that’s rare and I can probably only do that for one person. Father has a [Royal Chamberlain], but it’s not common to do. Although it does help!”

“I imagine it would. Such a class...hrr. Am I right in thinking it offers better Skills, or perhaps more unique ones?”

Lyonette nodded cautiously, trying to dredge up half-remembered lessons.

“I think so. It’s just an addition, so you can change classes and transform it like normal. It just makes you, well, better.”

She paused as Krshia mulled this over, and then had a crazy thought. She spoke before her courage failed her.

“Would you like me to give one to you?”

Krshia choked on her tea and nearly sprayed it all over Lyonette. When she’d finished coughing, she looked at the [Princess].

“You are joking.”

“No.”

Lyonette met her gaze, her legs trembling wildly.

“I’m serious. I could give it to you if you want.”

“Why? I am not your subject. And such a gift—”

“I gave Brunkr a [Knight] class. I think...well, I just think that he’d want me to help you if I could. And that’s the only thing I can do.”

Krshia looked at Lyonette. She sat back in her chair, speechless. When she spoke, it was distantly.

“Say I accept. I would receive a royal title and...nothing else? It would be a gift, yes, not an obligation?”

Lyonette hesitated. She frowned and gulped some tea.

“I don’t know. It’s been years—decades, really, since my family gave their blessing to anyone. We make [Knights] and [Lords] and so on, but businesses are different. It’s...I can remember my grandmother knew a fruit

seller who she made royal. I think it helped her business, but I can't remember if it did anything else. You don't have to, I'm just offering..."

"I see. But if it is so useful, why have your family not appointed more? Surely it would help your kingdom. What stays their paws...hands?"

"Trust, perhaps."

Lyonette looked wistfully up at the ceiling. She shook her head in response to Krshia's confusion.

"It's just...you see, it's so political back home. If my family gave a [Merchant] a royal blessing and he started working for another country, or denounced our kingdom, it would be a scandal, you see. And it's not as if my family meets with many ordinary people that often. Not that I think you're ordinary! I..."

"I know what you mean. So. That is what you offer and it is for me to accept or not. From what you say the risk is small. However."

Krshia got up and walked back and forth for a few seconds. Lyonette looked at her anxiously, regretting opening her mouth. Why had she said that? And yet—she remembered Brunkr and couldn't regret offering.

At last, Krshia slowed. She sat down heavily in front of Lyonette and looked around. Lyonette did too. Krshia's apartment wasn't large, but it was comfortable, and showed many years of care and hard work. The [Barmaid] remembered that Krshia had apparently come to Liscor decades ago to work.

"It has been long, and I have worked hard to get to where I am. I lost much."

Krshia raised her paw to forestall Lyonette.

“Much. Material goods and money...but I received a gift far greater than that in return from Ryoka Griffin. I do not begrudge you that. As for my nephew, I ache. Now I must rebuild, and yet I asked myself the other day whether it was worth trying, if I had the strength to do so another time. And now a gift is offered, unprompted. Would I be a fool not to take it?”

Lyonette held her breath. The Gnoll nodded.

“All things change. This is what we Gnolls know. To stay the same is to be a fool. So you offer and I respond thusly: yes. Lyonette, if you will give me a blessing, a royal title, I would accept with gratitude.”

She stared at the [Princess], and Lyonette stood. She trembled with nerves as much as anything else. She raised a hand and Krshia looked up.

“Hrr. Should I kneel?”

“No. I can...no. I just need to say a few words.”

Lyonette took a few breaths. She felt...she remembered staring at a Gnoll’s back, her legs and arms covered in sweat, holding a sword and feeling the skin of her palms sting. She blinked, and Krshia was looking up at her, waiting. Lyonette spoke, and felt a shiver as the words spun out from her heart. Ancient words. Familiar words. True words.

“I, Lyonette du Marquin, do solemnly grant you, Krshia Silverfang, and whatever business you pursue, my royal favor, now and unto perpetuity. You who have forgiven us when we did not deserve it. You, whose kin we called friend, however briefly. You, who have lost much—we offer our small blessing. Let the world know you are favored and let that favor grant you all the riches you wish for.”

She reached out and touched Krshia on the brow. The Gnoll bowed her head and Lyonette waited a second. Then she withdrew her hand. It was over.

“Did it...work?”

She looked at Krshia. The Gnoll blinked and touched the spot on her head, wrinkling her brows. She rolled her shoulders and sniffed the air and looked at Lyonette, tilting her head from side to side and shrugging.

“Hrm. I do not know. I do not feel different. But perhaps...let me sleep on it.”

She grinned, showing her teeth, and Lyonette smiled as well. There was a moment where the past was forgotten and they were just enjoying themselves. Two people, one step closer to becoming something like friends. Then it passed, leaving everything different. Krshia raised her teapot.

“More tea?”

Lyonette gulped. She looked at Krshia and smiled guiltily.

“Maybe. But first...could you tell me where the bathroom is?”

“Bow, Human worm!”

“No, *you* bow, you jerk!”

The Wandering Inn was full of shouting voices. Two in particular. Ilvriss staggered as Erin hit him with her authority, trying to force him down. The air was thick around the Drake, but his own aura of command pushed hers back. He pointed.

“I will not stomach such insolence from a *Human!*”

“Oh yeah? Oh *yeah?*”

The Drake [Lord] and Human [Innkeeper] circled each other like angry pigeons, trading insults, fighting with their respective auras. They circled rapidly, and then walked, and then finally sat and snapped at each other. Erin wiped sweat from her forehead and accepted a glass of water from Ishkr. Ilvriss looked up with bloodshot eyes and waved at the Gnoll.

“Give me a drink.”

Ishkr looked at Erin. She nodded and leaned back in her chair, exhausted. Mrsha leapt onto the table and licked her face.

“Give him something, Ishkr. I’ll kick him out if he’s being a jerk.”

“I’d rather leave...than stay at a Human inn.”

Ilvriss sat upright, looking hungover and miserable. Erin pointed to the door with a hand that shook.

“Go for it, buddy. It’s a nice walk through the slush.”

Ilvriss considered this and leaned back in his chair as Ishkr came out with a cup of cold water.

“I don’t answer to you, Human.”

He grimaced as he drank from the cup.

“Water? What am I, impoverished? Get me something stronger! Alcohol, if you even serve it. Not some cheap ale, but a proper Drake drink, like Firebreath Whiskey!”

The Wall Lord snapped at Ishkr, forcing the Gnoll to hurry behind the bar. The Drake did drink the water, though. Erin eyed Ilvriss.

“Haven’t you already had enough? You’re drunk already.”

“So? My affairs are none of your business. I will have you know that I am in mourning. I grieve and my drinking is thus excusable.”

Ilvriss grimaced as Ishkr came back with a mug brimming with the fiery orange liquid that had done so much damage to Seborn and Jelaqua yesterday. Erin glanced at the mug and then at Ilvriss.

“Is that because of Ulrien? Or Brunkr?”

“Who?”

The inn went quiet. Ilvriss looked around and grimaced.

“Ah. The two casualties of the Named Adventurer and her accomplice? No. This is...personal.”

He lifted the mug and drank down what must have been at least five shots of whiskey. Erin saw Jelaqua put a hand to her mouth, but Ilvriss only swayed a bit in his seat as he finished. He thrust the mug at Ishkr and the Gnoll sighed. Erin stared at him and raised her voice.

“No alcohol for the Wall Lord, Ishkr. Give him something else like milk and honey.”

“Milk and—who are you to dictate what I drink?”

“The [Innkeeper]. And it seems like you’re pretty upset, buddy. Why don’t you tell me about it?”

Erin scooted her chair over towards Ilvriss’ table. He eyed her, but seemingly didn’t have the energy to move away. Instead he let out a long-suffering sigh as Ishkr came back with warm milk and honey, a Mrsha favorite.

“So this is how far I’ve sunk, to be denied drinks at a Human establishment. If Periss could see me now...”

He shook his head, slumping in his chair as the shots of Firebreath Whiskey hit him all at once. Erin looked at the Wall Lord.

“Who’s Periss?”

“None of your business. And if you think I’ll drink this swill—what are you doing?”

Ilvriss was pushing away the mug when Mrsha leapt up onto his table. The Gnoll was staring at his mug and the Wall Lord instinctively drew it closer to him. Erin smiled.

“That’s Mrsha. She wants a drink. Ishkr! Can you make one for Mrsha? Thanks! Try it, why don’t you? It’s good!”

The Drake stared at Mrsha, who was eying his drink with clear desire. There was possibly no better endorsement than the longing on her small face. Cautiously, he sipped at the milk and his eyes widened.

“Sweet!”

“Isn’t it? We get Ashfire Bee honey here so we can make a lot of sugary stuff. This is a house special.”

As Erin had observed, sugar was a rare treat even for the rich in this world. Ilvriss began sipping at his drink and Mrsha, once she’d gotten her own mug, began happily lapping it up. Erin looked around.

The Horns of Hammerad were staring at her, and the Halfseekers were eating a very, very late breakfast. As for the Goblins...Ilvriss glanced at Headscratcher and Shorthilt as they paused in maintaining the small bucklers they carried into combat.

“So those are the Goblins. Hmf. I can see why this inn is abandoned. Tell me, Human. Are you insane, or just odd, as Shivertail claims?”

It took Erin a moment to realize he was talking about Zel, not Selys. She made a face at him.

“I’m not *odd*! I just think Goblins are people, and they saved my life! Besides, they haven’t hurt anyone. If you’re afraid they’re going to mug you, well...they won’t!”

Headscratcher nodded. Shorthilt paused and eyed Ilvriss’ rings until the other Hobgoblin jabbed him in the ribs. Ilvriss snorted.

“I am not *afraid*. Disgust keeps me from patronizing this establishment, not fear. I am capable of slaying however many Hobgoblins that infest this inn myself.”

He put a hand on the hilt of his sword and both of the Hobs growled. Headscratcher eyed Ilvriss, and Erin sat up, scowling.

“Stop bullying them! Can’t you not be a jerk for five seconds? I thought [Lords] were supposed to be noble, but you don’t act like it!”

Ilvriss glared back.

“I am a Lord of the Wall. I realize that means little to you, but it is my sworn duty to defend my city and Drakes as a whole from enemies of our kind. Goblins are one such threat. Traitors the other, which is why I fought to defend you with Shivertail in this very inn despite my hatred for all Humans. Do not lecture *me* about duty.”

Erin fell silent. She saw Ishkr pause as he went about the inn and the Halfseekers stop eating.

“Oh. Right. You did help. Thank you.”

She hadn’t asked for his help, but when she’d talked to Zel before confronting Regrika, he’d mentioned that he would bring someone he thought could help. By all accounts, Ilvriss had risked his life fighting in the city when he and Zel had been teleported.

There was a silence as Ilvriss looked at Erin and then around, noticing the silence his words had caused. Mrsha stopped lapping at her drink and curled up into a ball on the table. The Drake stared at her and then at Erin's face. Then he sighed.

“...I should be the one apologizing to you, Human.”

“What?”

Ilvriss sat a bit straighter and his voice was less slurred as he looked at Erin.

“It was my weakness that allowed Regrika Blackpaw and the traitor with her to escape. That they slew a Gold-rank adventurer...this was my fault and I apologize to you for it.”

“It wasn't your fault.”

Erin spoke automatically. Ilvriss glared at her.

“It was. Do not interrupt! It was my fault. Perhaps we were all at fault for underestimating our foes. Perhaps. But while Shivertail may have been the highest-level warrior there, I am most at fault. For I am a Lord of the Wall. When I fail, my failure is greater than any other. Thus I take responsibility. If you have any hatred, any regrets for what transpired, know that I am to blame.”

He sat straight and tall, both apologetic and proud at the same time. Mrsha uncurled to look at him and Erin closed her mouth. She frowned at Ilvriss.

“You keep saying you're a Lord of the Wall. But what does that really mean? You're a [Lord] in one of the Walled Cities, right? Is that really that special?”

Ilvriss' eyes flashed.

“More than special! We are nobility whose lineage extends back to the age of Ancestors, of *Dragons*! We built the Walled Cities with their help, to shelter our people. And though millennia have passed, my role is the same. To lead and inspire Drakes, to defend our home from any invaders, to pass justice as I see fit, to hold others of my station accountable. It is an honor, a calling, and a privilege. *That* is what it means to be Lord of the Wall.”

There was a brief silence after he had finished. Then a lapping. Mrsha tilted her mug and slurped loudly. Ilvriss looked at her. Erin rested her chin on her hands.

“So if you’re that important, why did you come all the way to Liscor? Shouldn’t you be at your Walled City, defending it?”

The Drake hesitated. He bowed his head.

“Yes. I should be. But I came here searching for the truth. The truth which your Runner friend hid. And which...I have now uncovered. Ah. Periss.”

He slumped again, and Erin saw Pisces look up from his table speculatively. She wondered what she should do, but it was Mrsha who padded over on the table and awkwardly patted Ilvriss on the shoulder. He stared at her and she sat by him, sipping from her mug.

“It sounds like she was really special to you.”

“She was. She was glorious, brave, a fine officer, and more. If I had known...”

Perhaps it was the drink, perhaps it was the absurdity of it. Ilvriss sat and drank his honeyed milk. Erin pulled her chair up to the table and patted his shoulder as the Drake bent over his mug.

“Come on, tell me all about it.”

He did. It was a confusing story, full of forbidden romance with a subordinate, chance meetings, battlefield exploits, and close calls. And sex. Erin carefully put her hands over Mrsha's ears when Ilvriss got to any lewdness. He was drunk and not a good storyteller, despite what he might have believed, but one thing was clear.

He had loved her. And now she was gone. Ilvriss finished one mug of milk, and then two and Mrsha matched him for every sip. And when he had finished, Erin sat with him and patted his shoulder.

"I'll get you back to Pallass. Don't you worry."

"I—thank you. I have no remains to inter, but I must notify her family in person and—and see to fitting funeral arrangements."

Ilvriss stared at the table. He looked so wretched that Erin called for some food. Mrsha wagged her tail. Ilvriss looked up as Ishkr brought him lunch.

"What is this?"

"Soufflé. It's egg and cheese and carrot and...it's good, okay? Hot, too."

"There is no way you could have made it quickly. Unless—is the Gnoll a [Chef]?"

"Nope. *I'm* the cook around here. But I have a food preservation skill. Go on, try it."

"Human cooking? I think I'll pass—"

Ilvriss' stomach rumbled as he pushed away the bowl. He stared at Erin and she grinned at him.

"Go on. Or Mrsha will eat it. Mrsha, no. You're getting your own. See? Ishkr has it right there. Be a good girl and sit down. Not on the table."

The Gnoll did, patting the table happily as Ishkr gave her a fork and warned her not to eat fast since the soufflé was hot. Grudgingly, Ilvriss emulated Mrsha's example. He was clearly trying to eat just so he could disparage Erin's cooking, but soon he was scraping the bowl with his fork.

"Not...bad. I will have another."

"Really? Good! Hey, when you go to Pallass, I wonder if I can find a way to make the door transport a bunch of people at once. I bet the Drakes there haven't had anything like my cooking!"

Ilvriss coughed, looking somewhat more alert after what might have been his first meal of the day. He hesitated as he glanced towards the magical door.

"Pallass. Yes. I forgot how inconvenient that might be."

"What?"

Erin looked at him. The Wall Lord grimaced.

"The Courier is not the issue. It is...personal. As a Wall Lord of another Walled City, my entering Pallass will result in political strife. I have enemies who would impede me."

"Oh. There are jerks in Pallass too, huh?"

"It is amazing how your crude Human expressions come so close to the truth."

Ilvriss sighed. He looked at the second soufflé and poked at the puffy crust with his fork. Mrsha waved for a second one and Ishkr sighed again.

"Well, I will not have to worry about that issue for a few days at least. Enough time to make preparations."

He began to bite into his meal. Erin saw Pisces sit up.

“Pardon me, but you said a few days? How far is Pallass exactly? Most maps I, ah, have read refuse to give the exact distance as a matter of Drake security.”

The Lord of the Wall might have been persuaded to talk to Erin and Mrsha, but he clearly wasn't happy about being addressed by Humans. He gave Pisces an arch look which the [Mage] returned and grudgingly replied.

“About the same distance as Invrisil. Four hundred miles give or take. More like three hundred and eighty.”

“Whoa. That's far. You sure a Courier can get there in a few days and not...weeks?”

Erin was hazy on distances, but three hundred and eighty miles seemed like a lot of distance to cover even if you had a car. Ilvriss sighed and cast his eyes to the ceiling.

“The average Courier can outdistance a horse over the course of a day, regardless of whether they could outrun one in a race. It will not take the Courier long. Hawk, I believe his name is.”

“Hold on, not long?”

Jelaqua frowned. She too had come alive with food and she was eating her fifth soufflé. Erin hadn't made that many and she was worrying Ishkr was running out in the kitchen. The Selphid began counting on her fingers.

“A mounted rider with an able mount can travel up to sixty miles per day without Skills. So that means it'd take...six days? Seven?”

Ilvriss sneered over his cup at Jelaqua.

“I said *horse*, not horse and rider. And Hawk is a veteran [Courier], not some City Runner who has barely achieved the rank but still has the [Runner] class. He is able to travel over a hundred miles in a day.”

Erin stared at Ilvriss.

“So it’ll take four days for him to get to Pallass. Maybe three. You know, you could just say that and not be a jerk about it.”

The Wall Lord growled at her. Mrsha poked him with a claw. He blinked incredulously at the Gnoll and then glared at Erin.

“Why are you sitting here? I am used to the dignity and *space* my station deserves. Were Peslas serving me, I would feel far more comfortable.”

“You’re staying at the Tailless Thief?”

Erin’s brows rose. Ilvriss smiled.

“Indeed. It is the only acceptable inn in the entire city.”

The [Innkeeper] shrugged.

“If you say so. I thought Peslas was kind of a jerk when I met him, though. But then, he’s sort of like you.”

“Stop *calling* me that!”

Ilvriss’ left eye began to twitch. Erin grinned at him, and then frowned seriously.

“But he really is one. You know, the Halfseekers were staying at his inn until he kicked them out. Just because Jelaqua’s a Selphid and Moore’s big.”

The Lord of the Wall looked up. Jelaqua waved at him and raised her voice.

“We don’t mind! We’re used to it. Besides, here is nicer. Oi, Ishkr! More soufflés! Give me three more! Moore and I are hungry!”

The Drake eyed the Halfseekers and looked troubled for the first time.

“Peslas ejected them? He should not have done that. I am familiar with the Halfseekers. A Gold-rank team that has featured two Drakes among their number. You there, Selphid.”

Jelaqua looked up, spoon halfway to her mouth.

“Me? I have a name. It’s Jelaqua.”

“Ivirith the Tempest. I recall. What became of two of your number? You had a Scorchling in your ranks a few years ago. Halassia Evergleam. What became of her?”

The Halfseekers paused and all three looked up. Moore’s face twisted and he bowed his head. Seborn looked at Ilvriss as Jelaqua glanced at the Redfang Goblins who had paused in their seats. That was all the answer Ilvriss needed. He bowed his head.

“I see. I trust her remains were sent back to her family?”

“They didn’t want them. We buried her ourselves.”

There was a strained note in Jelaqua’s voice. She stared at Ilvriss. Erin looked from her to the Wall Lord. She felt like she shouldn’t ask, but she had to.

“Um...what’s a Scorchling?”

“A half-Drake.”

Seborn answered for both of them. The Drowned Man gulped down another glass of water as he spoke, his deep and echoing voice somber.

“They’re a kind of Oldblood Drake. Only, the way their heritage manifests isn’t in wings or the ability to breathe fire. They’re born burnt by the fires within them. Most die with their mothers, but the few who survive live with their curse. The fire in their bodies makes their

scales flake off, and causes them pain. Scorchlings are half-Drake and half ash, or so it's said. In truth, they're just people with a curse."

"Shunned."

Moore spoke the one word and closed his eyes. Ilvriss nodded.

"They are. But some make a name for themselves even so. I knew of Halassia. She was born in Salazsar. That she considered you her allies, and that you took her in—I remembered your name, Halfseekers. For the kindness you offered Halassia when her kin would not, I thank you."

He bowed his head, surprising everyone again. Erin looked at him.

"You don't think Scorchlings are cursed?"

He glared at her.

"Half-Drake, you mean? Do I look like I'm afraid of ancient curses or believe in that superstition? No. And even if I did—half a Drake is still worth more than any Human, Gnoll, or any other species in this world. I personally believe such children cursed by our blood have the heart of true Drakes and should be treated as such."

His little speech caused a hush, and made the Halfseekers look at him differently. Erin too. She leaned over and whispered to Mrsha.

"Now I can't tell if he's a jerk or just pretending."

The Gnoll nodded. Ilvriss stared at both of them.

"I am going to leave now. Unexpectedly tolerable as this inn may be, I prefer the company of my own kind."

He rose, rummaging at his money pouch. Erin interrupted him.

"Oh come on. You have to stay for dessert at least. I was going to save it for dinner, but—Ishkr! Bring out the cake!"

The word ‘cake’ made Mrsha choke on her soufflé and everyone in the room look up. Ilvriss looked confused.

“Cake?”

It was a memory that Ishkr brought out of the kitchen, carefully set on a large plate. Erin saw the others in the room look at the cake and remember. She had first served it the night Brunkr had died. Erin stroked Mrsha’s head and smiled.

“It’s just cake, Ilvriss. It’s...good. I think you’ll like it. And it’s good to eat.”

She looked around, meeting the eyes of the Horns of Hammerad, the Halfseekers...Mrsha. Erin personally cut the cake and offered two slices to the Goblins, inviting them to call their friends. Ilvriss sniffed at his cake and watched as Mrsha hesitated over her slice. She looked sad for a moment, but then began to scarf the cake down. He pushed his own fork into the generously frosted slice of cake and bit. His eyes widened.

A sugar rush was not something Goblins had ever experienced. Erin saw Headscratcher’s eyes go round and Shorthilt immediately hunch over his cake as if he was afraid it would be stolen. She encouraged them to take three more slices down to their friends, but then decided to call them up—she feared the two Goblins would eat the extra cake themselves.

When she came back up, Ilvriss was scraping his plate with a fork and Mrsha was licking hers. She smiled expectantly at the Wall Lord. He cleared his throat, avoiding meeting her eyes.

“Mediocre at best, but I suppose it is original. I will have another piece. And some to take back with me. This is one dish that I have not encountered and I suppose I should share it with my subordinates. Unless... no, I’m sure Peslas can make the same.”

“I can give you another slice, but I’m afraid I have limited supplies of cake and I don’t want to sell it to someone who thinks it’s mediocre. Plus, you won’t get it anywhere else, Ilvriss.”

“What?”

Erin smiled evilly as the Wall Lord looked at her.

“As far as I know, no one has any baking powder or baking soda in this world but me. So that means my cakes are unique. No one can make anything like them even if they tried to copy it. Without me, the cake is a lie. No stupid Human, no cake.”

She paused and reconsidered her statement.

“Well, I suppose you could make cheesecake or angel food cake without baking soda. But that’s not *real* cake! Plus, I have whipped cream as well. Whoops! I forgot! Ishkr, for the second helping bring out the whipped cream!”

This time Ilvriss made the cake disappear as fast as Mrsha. He couldn’t really find an excuse for that this time, so he just mumbled about being hungry. That only made Erin laugh, and Mrsha giggled, on a sugar high of her own. And maybe it was the sugar, the alcohol, or something else, but Erin could have sworn she saw Ilvriss smile as well.

Just for a second. Then he was frowning at her and demanding to know how the cake was made. She laughed.

“With lots of sugar! And eggs! And flour and...well, it’s not good for you. You should probably exercise a bit.”

“I should?”

Ilvriss stroked at his face and then seemed to realize the state he was in for the first time. He felt at his eyes, his mussed clothing, and sat straighter.

“Dead gods, if Periss could see me—once I return, I’ll have to lead those lazy subordinates of mine in running laps around the walls! Ten to begin with, and I might as well teach Swifttail some sword drills while I’m at it.”

Erin saw a bit of fire ignite in his eyes. Maybe it was just burning pride, but it was what he needed, and she was glad of it. She smiled.

“Okay, but for now, I guess I will sell you that cake. And I have a special drink you might want to try before you go. It’s made with flowers.”

“Hmf. I suppose I can try—did you say another cake?”

“Yup. You can pay me a lot of money for it and give some to Peslas. Tell him he’ll never make it in a thousand years since I have an ingredient he can’t copy!”

Erin smirked, thinking of the way her pizza and hamburger recipes had been copied. Well, she’d have a monopoly on cake until people realized that Octavia was selling baking soda. She saw Ishkr bringing out the second cake and had to hold Mrsha back from getting at it.

Badarrow, Numbtongue, and Rabbiteater were having their slices of cake—and punching Headscratcher and Shorthilt who’d nibbled at the frosting—and Ilvriss was fumbling at his money pouch as Ishkr gave the second-to-last slice of cake to Yvlon. She’d eaten slowest out of everyone in the room.

By contrast, Ceria, Pisces, and Ksmvr had inhaled theirs. Actually, it was easier to say that of the inn’s guests, only Moore, Seborn, Erin, and Yvlon had shown restraint; everyone else had scarfed their first and second pieces down. Ksmvr was practically vibrating in place.

There was another whole cake sitting pristine in front of Ilvriss. Mrsha was nearly drooling over it. Erin was asking Ishkr to bring up the last slice

to Bird and Yvlon was fighting off Pisces and Ksmvr as she laughingly held her slice of cake up in the air. She turned to the doorway, holding her plate in her hands and froze.

The plate and slice of cake fell from her grip. The plate shattered onto the floor and Ksmvr and Mrsha dove for the cake. Pisces caught it in one hand and fled both of them. But Yvlon took no notice. She stared towards the open door, her face suddenly pale. Erin turned.

Someone was standing in the doorway, his body silhouetted against the setting sun. She shaded her eyes and a silver flash revealed a [Knight] in armor. He strode through the doorway, followed by a half-Elven [Mage] and a Dwarf dressed in full plate armor. The knight looked at Yvlon and removed his helmet. She gasped and spoke a name.

“Ylawes?”

Ylawes Byres smiled as he looked at his younger sister.

“Yvlon. At last I’ve found you.”

His eyes swept across the room and his warm smile froze for a second as he spotted Jelaqua, Moore, and Seborn. Then he saw the Redfang Warriors sitting at the back of the inn. They shot up from their table, grabbing at their weapons and yelling. Ylawes swore and grabbed for his sword. He unsheathed it as he tore the shield from his side and raised it—

A cake smashed into his face. Erin sighed as the [Knight] blinked and frosting spattered off his once-gleaming armor and onto the floor. Mrsha was giving Erin a betrayed look. Erin raised her hands.

“See, this is why you always bake *three* cakes. Ishkr, go get me another.”

She sat down as Ylawes blinked at her and the Dwarf by his side began to laugh. Erin sighed, and then smiled. Her inn was getting weird again.

Weirder, she should say. She looked at Ilvriss and he stared at her.

“Is your inn always like this, Human?”

Her laughter was his only reply.

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Chaos reigned at Lady Magnolia's estate outside of Invrissil. Servants of all stations rushed through the expensive and expansive hallways or gathered together talking urgently in small groups. Such confusion was not normal for any location under Magnolia's—or rather, Ressa's—authority, which made the scene all that much worse to behold. But perhaps it was inappropriate to describe the situation that way.

Chaos reigned over the Reinhart estate, pulling it out of its carefully controlled environment. If every house had an owner and every household its own ruler, then Magnolia and Ressa were the two monarchs of the estate. One was a tyrant, the other a generally benevolent ruler with a penchant for sweets. However, their rule had been upset, their authority overturned and chaos had gleefully seized the metaphorical reins and driven the household into madness.

Or did chaos as an abstract concept *rain* over the household? Yes, perhaps that was it. Chaos, that most insidious of forces, trickled down from the heavens or whatever nebulous plane of existence it resided in, filling the hearts of the people below with confusion.

It was said that Magnolia's servants were like her fingers. Some, many, were mundane [Maids] and [Manservants] who actually did what their classes suggested. They cooked, swept, and cleaned her many estates and enjoyed a protected, if sometimes unusual, lifestyle under their mistress's authority. But as anyone in the know knew, some of Magnolia's servants had...other functions.

They were assassins, spies, warriors, mages, and occasionally, rude. And when they went out into the world at her command, they resolved her

issues. Magnolia's fingers danced across the continent and sometimes the world, influencing events, securing power, removing obstacles—giving her the reputation of 'The Deadly Flower Blooming In the North'. That was a rather longwinded way of saying she was a flower, a [Lady], delicate, unsuited to war in her Skills and classes, but nevertheless possessed of thorns.

And she could make her fingers play an exquisite melody if she so chose. So what had let chaos—in any way, shape or form—into her mansion was that the hand that guided said fingers was different today. It was scaly, rather larger, and at the moment, clenching a sheaf of papers as the owner strode about Magnolia Reinhart's mansion, shouting at people.

It was probably easier to say it that way. There was chaos at Magnolia Reinhart's household. A simple sentence and easy to grasp. But then, what is chaos without *context*?

“Details!”

Zel Shivertail's voice boomed through the hallways, making two [Maids] jump and nearly drop the trays they were holding. They gingerly approached the huge Drake [General], wincing at the volume of his voice as he shouted loudly enough for half the mansion to hear.

“I want details! Get me every report, every message from every city that's sending soldiers to the front! And if they haven't written down the *exact* specifications of the soldiers they're sending—levels, classes, how many per unit, if there are officers leading—send a message back and demand an immediate reply! How hard is it to ask? I don't care if it's

nightfall—this is a military matter and they should know where their damned soldiers are at all times!”

He whirled and one of the Human [Maids] flinched. Zel stared at her and carefully plucked the single piece of fine white paper off of the tray she held. He looked at it and then bellowed again.

“And stop bringing me reports one at a time! Collect them, organize them, and—in the name of the Ancestors, *stop sneaking up on me like that!* Raise your voice if you want my attention!”

He turned and the [Maids] both fled at once. Zel raked a hand across the spines on his head and neck, muttering as he read down the short page. He crumpled the delicate and expensive paper with one claw.

“Ridiculous! ‘400 soldiers from the city of Befton will meet at the location provided as requested?’ That’s not a reply! It’s not coded, it’s not specific—what routes are these soldiers taking? Are they [Soldiers] or a militia? Do they have an officer? What are their levels? And when will they arrive? Do Humans not have any sense of *organization?*”

“I believe we do. However, you would not know it to look at my household at the moment. General Shivertail, has it occurred to you that our people do things differently for a reason?”

A calm voice interrupted the [General]’s ranting. Zel Shivertail swung around and pointed a claw at Magnolia Reinhart as she sat in a chair, sipping at a cup of tea. Splayed around her largest sitting room were tables that had been hurriedly carried in and filled with different reports on paper and parchment, communications by [Message] spell across the continent.

It was an impressive sight and being added to every second by servants hurrying into the room. Still, Zel was not happy and so he growled at Magnolia.

“Don’t patronize me, Reinhart. I don’t care if you Humans enjoy dancing around rocks while singing naked in the moonlight—this is a matter of organization and I can’t lead an army if I don’t know where it is or who I’m leading! You promised me an army! This is a nightmare! Don’t you have any [Strategists] or [Lieutenants] or—anyone who could have warned you what a nightmare this was?”

Magnolia Reinhart sighed and lowered her cup. Her face was calm and she was sitting still in an elegant dress, but her right foot jiggled—a sign of an impending sugar rush. She put aside her cup and another hand, Ressa’s, took it away before it could be refilled. The [Maid] tilted the cup so she could see the slurry of sugar mixed with tea and grimaced. Magnolia took no notice, but replied quickly and directly, focusing entirely on the Drake.

“While I know many such individuals, I do not, as a rule, consult with them on most matters, General Shivertail. I regret to say that I am woefully ignorant of all military affairs, which is why I sought a [General] worthy of the name to lead the army I was raising. My apologies—I thought simply requesting the soldiers would do. I had no idea coordinating their arrivals was so important.”

Zel Shivertail, the famous Lineholder, hero of two Antinium Wars and feeder of hungry Gnoll cubs everywhere, eyed Lady Magnolia sourly but relented. He nodded curtly and adopted a slightly more civil tone.

“I see. My apologies, Lady Reinhart, but this is a critical issue. Your army might actually appear, scattered though it is, but the instant the first group of soldiers arrives they’ll want to have a place to camp, food to eat, orders—and if they don’t have them, it will take days to sort out the disaster that will unfold by the time all of them get there.”

Magnolia winced and sighed.

“I see. Well, you have my support and my staff has a direct line with every city and town on the continent. I suspect we’ll be waking up many from their sleep—”

“They don’t have aides or officers stationed around the clock for calls like these?”

The [General] stared incredulously at Magnolia. She looked at Ressa, and her [Head Maid] shook her head.

“I’m afraid not. Perhaps some cities do, like Invril, but there are no laws and it’s very much dependent on the [Mayor] or whatever leadership is in place. Oh dear. I fear we do look rather bad compared to the Drake chain of command, don’t we?”

Zel took a deep breath. Yes, it was true. Humans were disorganized, at least in general. Or maybe it was Drakes who were too organized and judged other species by too high a standard? Whatever the case, Zel had grown up in the south of Izril, where even in the smallest Drake city-states, there was a clear chain of command at all times, the lines of communication were always open, and there was always *order*, even if the orders were incredibly stupid. Whereas here...

He looked around. The pink drapes, purple couches, cream colored walls, and deep red-and-violet carpets in the room made him feel like he was sinking into some kind of primeval swamp. He wasn’t used to elegance, had no sense or vocabulary to describe the subtle colors around him, and really didn’t care for the richness of Magnolia Reinhart’s mansion. Oh, he could admit it was pretty in some ways, but her luxuriant lifestyle was at odds with his simpler outlook.

But here he was. A Drake [General] in a Human [Lady]’s mansion. A first, if you didn’t count stories of Drakes burning and destroying Human settlements during war. He was here in the name of peace, or rather, war for

peace. He was her ally and she had invited him here, four hundred miles across the border that was marked by Liscor. And he had accepted.

The world might never be the same. Zel shivered at the thought. How many Drakes would call him a traitor once the news was out? How many Humans would be up in arms? But it had to be done. He was here, talking with one of the most dangerous Human women in existence because he needed her help and apparently, she needed his. To lead her armies, if nothing else.

But still, it was odd. Zel had had the most amazing of introductions to one of Lady Magnolia's servants—Reynold—when the man had driven up to the gates of Celum, late by over half a day, his carriage practically drenched in Goblin blood. However, he'd given Zel a completely uneventful ride to Magnolia Reinhart's estate, and she had welcomed Zel with open arms—as soon as she'd had her man Reynold pried from the driver's seat. They had talked briefly, and Zel had jumped on the first issue he'd spotted.

Rudely, he supposed. Zel sighed. He knew this was *not* how you treated your allies, much less a [Lady], but he was uneasy being around Magnolia and he was a [General], not a [Diplomat]. Zel Shivertail tried to make his tail stop twitching and took stock of the situation again.

“Let's go over this. You promised me an army. I thought you had one already, but apparently this one is comprised of levies from every city north of Invisil. And you have delivered if all these [Messages] are to be believed.”

“I do believe they are. It isn't rare for people to lie to me, but they seldom have the courage to commit it to writing.”

Magnolia inclined her head, smiling slightly and looking around for her tea cup. Zel grunted sourly.

“Well then, I’ll have an army at least forty thousand strong. But I have to warn you—it’s not going to be a good one. I’d rather have half again as many soldiers to take on the Goblin Lord.”

“Really? Why? I thought we had fine numbers. Or is it the quality of the soldiers you’re unhappy with? I can assure you they’re decent. Probably.”

Magnolia sat up with a frown. Zel sighed and shook his head. Civilians. He tried to explain patiently, as if he were talking to...Lyonette. Or Erin. Or Mrsha.

“You have the numbers Lady Reinhart, but that’s not an army. If I had ten thousand young men with swords, would you call that an army? And no, before you speak, it doesn’t matter if they’re all [Soldiers] because they’re all soldiers of different cities. They haven’t trained together, don’t necessarily know the same orders or fight the same way—and I don’t know how many officers there are.”

“And that’s a problem? You *are* a [General].”

“A [General] without a trained army is like a sharp mind and an unresponsive body, Miss Reinhart.”

“Ah. Oh, I do see now. Oh dear.”

Magnolia frowned. She wasn’t unintelligent, Zel could readily admit. She tapped at her lips and glanced at Zel.

“If it’s a matter of officers...I can see about levying some from more cities. Will that help, or will their unfamiliarity only exacerbate the issue?”

Zel shrugged.

“I don’t know. They could be useful...or not. I’m afraid I don’t know how well you Humans train your soldiers. I’ve seen good leadership and bad on the field of battle, but you don’t standardize your training.”

“While Drakes do. I am familiar with that. Your military chain of command is quite renowned across the world.”

The Drake grunted in response to the compliment. He looked over another sheaf of [Messages], speaking sourly.

“I’d give one of my claws for a few Drake [Lieutenants] or a battalion to fight with. A pity no Drake armies could cross north of Liscor without starting a war.”

“Hm. That’s very true. I did think about it, you know. But of all the mercenary groups in Izril—and there aren’t many—the only one of note was Liscor’s own army. And while they are for hire, I’m sure they wouldn’t respond to my requests and if they did...”

Zel looked up from the reports.

“No.”

“Indeed not.”

The [General] shook his head.

“That army is...not the kind you want if you value peace. I’m sure they’d manage to start a war if they came north. And given the uniqueness of their army, my Skills as a [General] would be least effective leading them.”

“That was my understanding. It is a pity though. They are formidable, for all of their detracting factors.”

Magnolia sighed. She found her teacup at last and wrestled with Ressa briefly before retrieving it. The [Head Maid] reluctantly filled her cup and Magnolia sipped it. She mused out loud.

“How does the saying go again? One Drake’s trouble, two are a fight, and three will burn your house down?”

She glanced at Zel swiftly, but the Drake didn't react openly to her comment. He kept reading another report in silence and jotting down notes on another piece of parchment. After a minute he looked up.

"What are four Drakes, then?"

"A war, I believe."

The [General] grunted. It wasn't quite a laugh. Magnolia watched him cautiously and flicked her eyes up towards Ressa. The [Maid] shrugged and Magnolia pursed her lips. After another short break she spoke lightly but cautiously.

"We have not had a chance to speak long I'm afraid, Mister Shivertail."

Zel didn't react to being called Mister either. He turned one eye towards her and flicked his tail slightly.

"We didn't. My apologies, but I decided to sort this out right away once I realized the issue."

"Quite, quite. But ah, aside from our commitment to work together, you and I have quite a few issues we should discuss."

"Really? It seems simple to me. You need a [General], I want to kill the Goblin Lord. And Az'kerash. Who you knew was alive for *years* and never did anything about."

His claws tightened slightly on the parchment and Ressa tensed ever so slightly. Magnolia subtly leaned back to pat her friend on the leg and spoke.

"Yes. However, you never gave me a chance to explain my reasoning."

Zel paused and looked up. Two [Porters] paused with twin stacks of reports. He nodded approvingly and they hurried over to the table in front of him.

“Good. These are—organized? Excellent.”

The Drake blinked in surprise and began crossing off names on the list he’d compiled, checking estimated arrival times with each city and creating a master list, a big picture of his army for him to look at. He wasn’t good at this kind of work—it was the kind of thing he liked to let [Strategists] sort out—but he could do it in a pinch. He got a rhythm going before he addressed Magnolia again.

“Fine. Tell me why you let him live.”

“A few reasons spring to mind. To begin with, I’m embarrassed to say that I thought he was more your people’s problems than mine and uninclined to start trouble so soon after the last Antinium War.”

Magnolia leaned forwards, speaking crisply despite the late hour. She gestured to the map of the continent that Zel was using as a reference on one of the tables.

“This was the same Necromancer who caused so much harm during the Second Antinium Wars and proved so difficult to defeat—and not even kill, it seems. I knew he must have lost nearly all his undead after his defeat, so I was content to let him go into hiding.”

“And replenish his forces? How long were you willing to wait? Until he appeared and started destroying Drake cities?”

“Hardly. I was more hoping that he would reappear and the Antinium, Drakes, and everyone else in the nearby vicinity would join up to destroy him. You do recall that he made rather fierce enemies of every species on the continent.”

“I do.”

“Yes, well, I decided he could be left alone for those reasons. Additionally—he may be powerful, but he is still only one [Necromancer].

The limits of his powers were rather neatly pointed out in the last Antinium War. He can raise a powerful army—one that can level cities and rout lesser armies true, but only one army of finite size. That’s not as grave a threat as six Antinium Hives or a Goblin King, is it?”

Zel caught himself nodding and stopped with a grimace. Magnolia smiled and went on, watching his reactions.

“Add that to a final consideration, General Shivertail. A [Necromancer] is a powerful mage, but specialized. He can raise armies, but not throw around spells that destroy armies by themselves. He is defined by his creations and while those creations can be terrible, they are linked to him. If the [Necromancer] dies, his army is leaderless, mana-less.”

The pieces clicked. Zel looked up as his brain switched over from corroborating reports to what Magnolia was saying.

“You were going to assassinate him.”

“Indeed.”

Magnolia smiled brightly and sipped at her tea cup. She reached out to grab a sugar cube—Ressa snatched the bowl away.

“My intention was always to kill Az’kerash. Sooner rather than later, but I knew I had only one opportunity, so I wanted to be sure, absolutely sure, of my success. That meant I had a short list of about six individuals who could do the job. I did consider asking an Archmage, but that could be tricky...the problem was that of the six, there were only two I could contract discreetly and be sure of. Neither one accepted my offers, and I did offer quite a lot.”

“Huh. That’s the problem with [Assassins], I suppose.”

Zel raised a magical quill and scribbled on his list, highlighting a discrepancy for later. Magnolia laughed.

“As a matter of fact, only one of the six I was considering for the job was an actual [Assassin]. I wanted the *best*, General Shivertail, and I don’t underestimate my foes. My first pick for the job would have been the infamous leader of the Forgotten Wing Company, Three-Color Stalker.”

The Drake looked up and his tail twitched in surprise.

“*Her?*”

“She *is* one of, if not the most deadly [Rogues] in existence. And she is more adept at slaying enemy [Commanders] on battlefields than most conventional [Assassins]. Who better to deal with a target that is functionally immune to poison and is no doubt warded with many magical artifacts?”

Magnolia swirled the tea around in her cup. It was minty, although you would never have known that with as much sugar as it held. She lifted her cup.

“Do excuse me, Ressa, but pass me the bowl of sugar or I’ll throw this at you. And I should ask again as a good host—would you like tea, General Shivertail? Something else? A snack, perhaps?”

Zel and Ressa both shuddered, having tasted Magnolia’s tea. The [General] was shaking his head and then paused. He looked up. He *was* in the mansion of one of the richest [Ladies] in the world, after all.

“If you have it...milk with honey.”

“Milk with honey?”

Magnolia blinked. Zel smiled.

“I recently developed a taste for it. Milk with honey, if you have it. Ashfire Bee honey to be precise. And if you have bacon or sausage, wrap it in dough and fry it a bit.”

“I’m sure my [Chef] can make that. Ressa, see to it, would you? That’s an intriguing dish. What is it called?”

Zel grinned to himself as Magnolia blinked at him, uncomprehending.

“Pigs in the blanket. It’s a Human dish.”

“Not one I know. Ressa? I want some too. Add lots of honey to my milk.”

The [Head Maid] had slipped out the door and whispered briefly with a servant stationed outside. She swiftly returned to Magnolia’s side. Zel eyed Ressa. She was wary of him and he could sense she wasn’t just someone who cleaned around the mansion. Well, whatever. He nodded at Magnolia.

“So Three-Color Stalker denied your request?”

Magnolia sighed loudly.

“I don’t believe she ever read it. She’s an odd individual. I sent her a number of cards and paid the [Couriers] to report back on how she received them. As I understand it, she *ate* two of them, gold leaf and all.”

“What?”

“That’s what I said. I’m not sure if it was an insult or just her personality. And she has never replied to me. Well, not in words. I believe after my sixteenth letter she sent me a message back by City Runner. I received a badly decomposed muffin that had been in transit for about six months. It had travelled across the sea by boat and was delivered to my house. I thought it was poison when I got it.”

“Huh. That is odd. I’d heard there was something weird about each of the leaders of the Four Great Companies, but...”

Zel frowned as he went back to his reports. A muffin? That was Baleros for you. War-loving freaks. Not that he could really speak as a Drake. He

looked up as a thought struck him. It had to be asked.

“...What kind of muffin?”

“What kind?”

“Was it blueberry? Plain? Apple? Insect?”

Magnolia traded a swift glance with Ressa.

“You know, I didn’t think to...that could be a clue. Or something. If Commander Foliana—Ressa? Make a note. Find out if anyone recalls what the muffin looked like.”

“Yes, milady.”

Zel eyed the [Head Maid] as she bowed slightly. He coughed.

“That’s an interesting maid you employ, Miss Reinhart.”

Magnolia laughed.

“Oh, Ressa? Don’t mind her glaring. She is protective of me. And nagging.”

“And armed.”

The [General]’s calm look made Ressa shift, and the impassive woman’s face hardened a bit. Magnolia stopped smiling and glanced at Zel.

“She is my protector, General. Rest assured I didn’t invite you here to kill you. I’d like to think I’m a bit smarter than that.”

“It never crossed my mind.”

Zel lied as he worked his way down the first stack of papers. He glanced at Magnolia and Ressa again and decided to ask another one of the questions that was on his mind.

“Very well. Say you’ve convinced me your intentions were good around the Necromancer. That still doesn’t explain why you wanted me, a *Drake*, to lead your army against the Goblin Lord. You have capable leaders in the north. Why not let your famous Lord Tyrion Veltras handle the Goblins?”

Magnolia’s face went sour at Tyrion’s name and Zel recalled too late that the Five Families weren’t exactly enamored with each other. He cursed internally. Human politics. Even at his best, he could barely stay aware of what went on in Drake lands.

“I don’t want to give that idiot a chance to shine, General Shivertail. Moreover, I don’t want a [General] for a few weeks or even a year. I had hoped you would see the long-term benefits of working together.”

“So your letter hinted. And what exactly did you have in mind?”

“Well…”

Magnolia sat up and was about to launch into her carefully-planned speech at last when a knock sounded on the door. She slumped and Ressa scowled at the unlucky interrupter.

“Enter.”

“Your pardons, Lady Reinhart.”

“*Reynold?*”

Magnolia sat up and Zel turned as Reynold stepped through the door. The [Butler] was wearing a new, pristine suit and his hair had been combed. More to the point, all of his wounds had been healed and he was no longer drenched in blood. He bowed to Magnolia and Zel as a [Maid] stood at his side. Sacra, or as Laken would have known her, Odveig, bowed as well, her eyes flicking to Zel and then to her mistress.

“Reynold, I thought you were asleep! You should be resting—thank you for running over those Goblins, by the way. I received a missive from Wales that you had saved quite a number of people by buying them time, but really! You should be asleep!”

The Lady Reinhart wavered between scolding and praising Reynold by turns. He bowed crisply and spoke carefully, keeping his eyes on Zel as the [General] appraised him and Sacra.

“I do apologize, Lady Magnolia, but I was told that General Shivertail was concerned with the state of the levied forces from the cities. As I have experience in that field, I believe I can manage the reports and let the general concern himself with more important issues.”

Zel could tell Reynold and Sacra were both warriors at a glance. The way they stood, the way they looked at him—their uniforms did nothing to hide that from his gaze. He nodded at Reynold as he set down a piece of parchment.

“Thank you for driving me...Reynold, is it? Are you a former [Soldier] of some kind?”

Reynold hesitated and behind him, Magnolia’s eyes flicked to him. But then the [Butler] nodded.

“I was a [Lieutenant], sir. An officer in charge of a cavalry unit. I have...experience in combat. And in war. I fought twice against Drakes in the Bloodfields.”

He waited for Zel’s response as the room went still. The Drake stared at Reynold and saw his companion, the [Maid] called Sacra, tense ever so slightly. He simply nodded.

“I understand. I’d be glad to let you take over, Reynold. And can I assume your companion knows war as well?”

Reynold bowed slightly.

“Miss Sacra is also familiar with military matters, General Shivertail. With your permission, we will tabulate a full list for your appraisal within the next few hours.”

“Excellent! Thank you, Reynold.”

Magnolia shot to her feet, clapping her hands lightly. She looked at Ressa and turned to Zel.

“I forgot Reynold and Sacra could be helpful. Do forgive me. Why don’t we let them take over—Ressa, they’ll need stamina potions, food, drinks, whatever they want. But I want those wrapped bacon snacks myself. General Shivertail, let us retire to another location.”

Zel raised his brows, wondering if he should protest. But one look at Reynold and Sacra as they began poring over his work reassured him they were competent. He let Magnolia steer him out of the room and down a corridor.

The next sitting room he found himself in was more intimate, and would have been familiar to Ryoka and Erin. Zel shifted and wondered why the couch had to be *pink*. But he had to admit, he was grateful for a chance to relax and by this point the milk and snacks had arrived.

“Oh! What a treat.”

Magnolia was salivating over the crisp, hot rolls of bacon wrapped in dough. She chewed on one, sipped from her honey and milk drink, and promptly ordered another plate made. Ressa took one look at the bits of bacon and cancelled the order.

“Ressa!”

“You don’t need that much food.”

“I can have it if I want. Look at General Shivertail. *He’s* eating.”

“He’s bigger than you are and a warrior. He can burn the energy. You’ll just get fat. Fatter.”

“How dare you! This dress is very slimming, I’ll have you know.”

“Yes. Too bad it can’t work miracles.”

Zel watched the [Lady] and [Maid] bicker like old friends for a few seconds before coughing. Instantly, both Magnolia and Ressa looked at him, all business.

“So I’m here to help you kill the Goblin Lord, and then the Necromancer. But from what you keep hinting at, you want more than that. Lady Reinhart, it’s time to stop dancing around before we trip on our tails. What do you really want with me?”

Lady Magnolia Reinhart grew still. She sat across from Zel Shivertail and looked him in the eye. Once, Magnolia had sat at this very couch—or one much like it—and bullied and played games with two young women. That was then. Now, she sat and addressed Zel Shivertail as an equal. Her voice was steady and unadorned with any Skill as she spoke.

“I asked you to join me, Zel Shivertail, because I want to work with you. I have sent you letters—hounded you, I will freely admit—over the years because I wanted you and none other. Not just to guide my armies, but to form an alliance with me. To defend this sorry continent and deal with the many problems of our world. And if you accept, you will be the first.”

Zel sat in his seat, back straight, not touching the snacks or his drink. He looked at Magnolia and felt the hum of danger in the back of his head. It was distinct, far-off. Danger to him? Or someone else? He sensed that he was facing an important decision and wished he was sure of how he’d respond or what she would say.

“The first? What do you mean by that?”

Lady Magnolia straightened her dress.

“I have sent many letters to many individuals across the world, General Shivertail. But two I have bothered most consistently. It is my hope that if you announce your decision to work with me, the second individual I have contacted will lend his great strength to me. You see, I have a plan that involves you, and you are the first.”

“Who is the second?”

“Niers Astoragon. The Titan.”

The name fell into the room and silenced it. Zel felt his heartbeat accelerate as thunder rumbled in his head and pieces started to fall into place. He felt like he was staring at a picture and was only uncovering it one piece at a time. But the grand scheme of it...he wondered whether Magnolia’s ambitions were what Sserys had feared or what he hoped for.

“The famous strategist of Baleros. Why do you want him?”

“Isn’t it obvious?”

Zel grunted at Magnolia’s disapproving look. He understood what, but not *why*.

“An army. You want us to lead an army.”

She nodded. Her fingers were laced together, and Ressa was looking from her mistress to Zel. They hid their emotions well, but Zel could tell they were nervous. Magnolia went on.

“It is similar to a thought exercise, General Shivertail. How would you go about creating the most powerful army? I am no [Strategist], so I thought of an answer that involved people. Two. A world-famous [General] and an unbeatable [Strategist]. Two of the highest-level individuals on the planet,

men or rather, a Fraerling and Drake that all recognize as being of sound character and honor. You two could lead any army, and I would give you an army of legends. Magical artifacts, arms, mercenaries...my coffers can fund whatever is needed.”

“That sounds...plausible.”

It sounded insane. Why would Niers Astoragon, a [Strategist] whom Zel had never met in his life, travel from Baleros to Izril? But if Magnolia was serious—and her eyes were purely focused and honest as far as Zel could tell—she had a point. Still, Zel felt compelled to point out an obvious flaw.

“If you’re talking hypothetically about a perfect army, even in the abstract, you only have two parts of the puzzle. A [General] to lead and a [Strategist] to coordinate is a solid combination, but the wildcard that can take an army apart is a [Mage]. Without a powerful spellcaster, there are ways to destroy even the best-equipped army.”

Magnolia smiled.

“I know that. But the [Mage] I already have. I know a...magic user beyond any other. If I had you and Niers, I think he would join too. And there are many more I would reach out to, many whom I think would join once they saw what I was attempting to create. So I would have a leader, a planner, and a spellcaster. Three to lead an army.”

“And do what? Carve out an empire?”

“No. To create a resolution to this world’s issues.”

Zel stared. Magnolia steepled her fingers.

“Consider this, Zel Shivertail. In this world of ours, there is war. Always war. From Baleros to Terandria, there is always a conflict going on. And some threaten to destroy entire species. We are threatened by the Antinium, a menace we have never seen before. Twice we have gone to war and twice

made peace. But I think you and I know they are planning for a third war. A final war and I am not of the opinion we can be so complacent about them this time.”

Zel thought of Pawn, of Klbkch, Xrn, and nodded slowly.

“No. They are...changing.”

Magnolia nodded.

“And that is only the tip of the iceberg. In Rhir, the Demons fight with the Blighted King. As they have always done, and yet...there was an attempt on the Blighted King’s life last week. Imagine what would have happened had it succeeded? And the King of Destruction stirs from his slumber at last. Meanwhile, a new [Emperor] has emerged in Chandrar, the Emperor of Sands who already controls a good sixth of the continent. Either one could threaten the world.”

“You seem to be listing a lot of problems. But is this hypothetical army of yours a solution?”

“Not a hypothetical army, Zel Shivertail. A very real one that could become reality. Nations and species fight, but we do not *have* to. If we could resolve the Antinium issue in Izril, make some kind of peace between Drakes and Humans, we could turn our attention to the real issues in this world! But it is the Antinium and the Necromancer I think of now. The Drakes are disunited and we Humans fight each other. We need a powerful force—beyond what one [Lord] or Walled City can raise. A truly powerful force, one made up of every alliance that can be forged. You and I have seen it before.”

“General Sserys’ army.”

Another piece fell into place. Zel walked backwards in time, saw a massive army of Drakes, the hope of the continent. Humans, riding south to

fight against a common enemy. Death and silence. A destroyed army and Sserys' last words.

The past met the present. Magnolia nodded. She had been there too.

"I believe that if we Humans had marched with you, if we had all committed as one or given General Sserys more time, worn down the Antinium by parts rather than risk a final confrontation...perhaps we might be living in a different world. But yes, that is what I refer to. Another army, only this one led by you, Zel Shivertail. One that would either destroy or push the Antinium off this continent for good."

The idea rocked Zel back in his chair. Not because it was daring, not because it was impossible—but because it was what he had been saying for years. Hadn't he told those idiots in the Walled Cities and councils the exact same thing? Zel's words came back to him. Drakes should be uniting against a common foe, forging alliances, focusing on the real threat. He looked at Magnolia and saw her looking at him.

"I have ears throughout the world Zel Shivertail. And what I dreamed of, you shouted. You have been ignored by your people, but I agreed with every word you said. Except that I think the Antinium are only the start."

"You want to create a force powerful enough to destroy both the Necromancer and the Antinium? And what then, end the war between our species? End that idiocy at the Blood Fields that happens every year?"

Magnolia nodded. Zel shook his head.

"Impossible. Every Drake city would—you'd have to shove peace down their throats while you held a blade in the other hand. And I bet the Humans would be the same."

"If that is what is necessary, I would do it. We must have *peace*, General Shivertail. Peace! This war is senseless and it wastes lives. I would end

that.”

“How?”

Magnolia’s gaze was steady as she met Zel’s.

“I would open the High Passes and encourage Humans and Drakes to settle in each other’s lands. Peace might not arrive in a year or a decade, but exposure to one another and peace—by whatever means—would bridge old wounds, or so I feel. At the very least, I think the Gnolls would welcome the opportunity to travel the north as well as the south.”

The thought of that—Zel’s mind spun as he imagined the High Passes opened. That would let armies through—but also trade. It would mean war if the Humans and Drakes weren’t already at peace, but if they were...

“And what then? You’ll disband the army?”

Magnolia snorted.

“Hardly. There is far more to do. Far more pressing issues that may well lead to a world war, a conflict between continents. If I could stabilize one continent, I see no reason why I shouldn’t turn my attention to another one.”

“So say you do. What would you fix?”

Slowly, Magnolia Reinhart began to count on her fingers, her voice echoing in the sitting room.

“The Demons of Rhir. The Emperor of Sands in Chandrar. The King of Destruction. Those idiots in Terandria, and the state of war in Baleros. Oh, and those disgusting slavers in Roshal too. Those are the major issues I see in the world.”

It was like she was making wishes on a shooting star. Zel shook his head. Any one of those issues was unsolvable in his eyes. Oh, he could see

parts of how to fix the issues—smashing the King of Destruction’s armies and beheading that idiot would solve a lot, but the scope of what Magnolia was proposing was...

A [Strategist] like Niers Astoragon could probably see what she was proposing, though. The Titan? Zel had met two Fraerlings in his life. He wondered what the Titan would say. If they met, would they even be able to work together? A good [General] and [Strategist] were like a married couple. If they didn’t agree—

Ridiculous. It would never happen. But part of Zel wondered. Magnolia *was* rich. Niers Astoragon was a mercenary, for all he was a commander. And he was renowned for being able to travel vast distances at the drop of a hat, appearing on a battlefield hundreds of miles away from where he had last been spotted in a day’s time. He was also open to communication. If she sent him a letter, or if Zel did—

Impossible. But the [General] kept listening.

“An army solves many issues. I have no doubt you and Niers Astoragon could push back the Demon King and rout his armies if you were joined with armies from the other continents. As for Chandrar—the King of Destruction and the Emperor of Sands are already at war. One could destroy the other, but neither can be allowed to overtake the continent. The other issues can be solved with diplomacy, but one must be a world power to make other such powers agree to talk.”

Magnolia was speaking as if it were all set in stone, as if it were all possible. Zel shook his head.

“You’re overestimating me, Reinhart. I may be a high-level [General], but I wouldn’t bet on a battle between me and the King of Destruction, even with the Titan commanding my army. You need more than one army.”

“So I shall have more. Many more. That is why Izril is the start, General Shivertail. Bring peace to Izril, and I can send five, six, *eight* armies to do battle with the King of Destruction if need be. And other nations will do the same. You see, what I want is peace. And for that, I need an army. Not just one army, but a collective of every nation that wants peace in the world.”

A coalition. Zel shivered. Magnolia went on, her eyes shining with a distant future.

“Imagine it. A centralized peacekeeping force made up of forces from all nations. A governing body that exists beyond [Kings] and has the authority and strength to deal with threats to our world. It could be possible. The Goblin Lord and the Antinium are the first step. Eradicate them, and consolidate a base of power, and more will follow. That is why I need you, Zel Shivertail. You can lead an army. You and I represent a force far greater than our individual strengths.”

And like that, she lost him. Zel looked at Magnolia, suddenly broken out of the trance her words had caused. She was still looking ahead, still staring at that vision—and he remembered what Sserys had said.

Peace.

And Zel understood a bit of what had scared his mentor and friend. He shifted, and Magnolia broke off speaking sharply. The moment of—inspiration—flickered out.

The Drake carefully reached out and snagged one of the pigs in the blanket. He bit into it and chewed. It was cold, but the food was still good. And it was grounding. He took a sip and spoke softly.

“It sounds like an amazing dream, Lady Reinhart. But I’m afraid I don’t quite buy into all of it. I don’t think it will work.”

Magnolia looked at him and the light in her eyes faded a bit.

“Why not?”

“It’s an abstract idea. It’s a plan with a thousand moving parts. It assumes you will get the Titan’s attention, he will come here, that we won’t all be defeated in a battle, that you can make peace...and that I stay after dealing with the Goblin Lord and Az’kerash.”

Zel sipped at his drink, keeping his tail still. Magnolia stared at him.

“I see. But you agree the Antinium are a threat, don’t you? Why would you—”

“I don’t know if I’ll stay. Because I don’t trust you.”

Zel stood up abruptly. He saw Ressa tense, but Magnolia held up a hand. The [General] ignored Ressa and stared down at Magnolia. She looked up at him, fearless, but wary.

“I don’t like you, Human. I don’t mind most Humans, but you I judge from what I’ve heard and seen over the years. I don’t *trust* you, Magnolia Reinhart. You speak of peace, but you would see it through war.”

“How else?”

Magnolia blinked calmly at Zel, and he lost his momentum.

“How else? What do you mean?”

“How else would you do it, General Shivertail? You must know there are foes that will not be dissuaded by any amount of talking. There are tyrants and monsters who wear flesh like costumes and parade around pretending to civility in this world. They must be ended. How else would you do it besides war?”

“That’s not what I mean. It’s the fact that *you’re* the one taking charge that I object to.”

Zel shook his head. He felt frustrated—because he partially agreed with what Magnolia had said. And yet—

“No one person can be above others. Drakes have no [Kings] for that reason. If you went about ‘solving’ issues and removing whomever you liked, what would make you better than they are? What would allow people to trust you?”

“Nothing at all. I understand that. I have a reputation for trickery and underhandedness. I understand that General Shivertail. Which is why I need you and Niers Astoragon. I need people who are what I am not. Honorable, trustworthy. And that is why I propose a council, an alliance of people to manage this attempt, this army. I invited you to my estate as an equal, and I propose that you and I find other equals who can balance our opinions and make the right choices.”

The words made sense, but the mouth they came from—Zel shook his head again.

“No. I can’t trust that. I will not. Not alone, at any rate.”

Magnolia rose too, slowly. She was eying him with concern, and he felt like—

A Drake [General] stared at a young Human girl as she held out her hand. Peace. He looked into her eyes and saw war.

“I won’t agree to your plans. It sounds...unreal. And I don’t trust you. I’m sorry, but I came here for aid against Az’kerash. I will help you with the Goblin Lord, and in exchange you’ll help me with the Necromancer. That is why I came here. More than that I won’t promise.”

Magnolia took Zel’s words silently. For a few moments she stared at Zel, face impassive, and then she slowly nodded.

“I see.”

“Don’t mistake me. I think our peoples should work together. But you—I won’t ally myself with you blindly. If I did commit to an alliance, if I even thought about raising an army and tying my name to yours for a greater cause—it would have to be after I talked to the Titan himself. Him and this ‘magic user’ you’re hinting about.”

Magnolia’s eyes widened. Zel turned to her and bared his teeth.

“You have too many secrets, Reinhart. I don’t trust you at all. But I will admit—you make sense. And you have money, which funds armies and wins wars. Given that—if you can introduce me to people I can trust, I might, *might* come back with them and agree to your insane plan.”

Lady Magnolia Reinhart’s face was completely blank for a second, and then she burst out laughing. It surprised Zel so much he took a step back and nearly tripped onto the couch. Magnolia sat, chuckling, and Zel saw her wipe tears out of her eyes.

“Oh dear. That is the most—Ressa, I hoped for fortune and I received something like it. You want to meet my magic user and the Titan? Well, I can’t promise either, but I will ask! And oh my, if I arranged such a meeting...time to use every carrot and stick I think, Ressa.”

“Indeed, milady.”

Zel glared suspiciously at the two Human women.

“What’s so funny? Who is this magic user?”

Magnolia shook her head and brushed away a tear with a finger.

“Secrets, my dear General Shivertail. I cannot reveal who he is...yet. And I have a few more matters I’d gladly discuss with you and him—perhaps that’s the very key to getting him to agree, Ressa. Bring up the children—I’m sure I could get one of them to give him one of their devices if he’d agree—”

“One of those ‘tablets’, perhaps?”

“Indeed. Why, we could arrange it within the week if we put everything together. After the Goblin Lord of course, but if we sent Reynold to collect one and I sent a [Message]—”

The two were suddenly chatting with each other, talking about the magic user. Zel couldn’t make heads or tails of the conversation though, and cleared his throat. Magnolia broke off and smiled apologetically.

“Do forgive me General Shivertail. But I think I can convince you after all. As for the Titan—I will indeed try to talk to him.”

“I...see. Well, I’m willing to meet with either one.”

Zel wasn’t sure what he was talking himself into, but curiosity had taken hold and...he was already in trouble for coming this far. He might as well have something to show for it. Magnolia nodded briskly, suddenly all business. She looked at Zel—far more concretely now, and with none of the idealism she’d shown when talking about the future.

“For now it seems like we are allies of convenience, General Shivertail. I’ll give you an army—ragtag and disorganized though it may be—and you’ll help me deal with the Goblin Lord. After that, we can discuss Az’kerash.”

She hesitated and raised a finger.

“I *may* also need you to squish an annoying pest that’s popped up close to my lands. I seem to have a problem with [Emperors], or at least one...”

Zel folded his arms in disgust. One second she was talking about peace, the next...an [Emperor]? How? Wait, hadn’t he heard Erin saying something about an [Emperor] to Ryoka one time? It had been a passing conversation...Zel brushed that aside for the moment.

“I’m not your sword to be pointed at anyone you please, Reinhart. Besides, you’re the scion of a famous house. Why can’t you assassinate them in the middle of the night or crush them yourself?”

Magnolia smiled in embarrassment.

“I ah, seem to have a problem with loyalty and hired killers at the moment. Which is another problem I’d like to discuss—as for dealing with him myself, I *was* aware of the issue, you know. I had hoped he’d be content with a village or two, but it seems this damnable Goblin situation has sent people rallying to his banners. And while I’m sure our cultures are different, you must agree that attacking a local hero is not generally helpful to one’s reputation.”

“True. So why deal with him at all? You’re afraid he’ll take your lands? Can’t you...talk to him?”

Zel grunted. Magnolia hesitated.

“I don’t like [Emperors]. Every one I’ve met has had a few tricks up their sleeves. Nasty ones. And as a [Lady], I am regrettably disadvantaged when opposing them. Hierarchies and social classes, you know. I prefer not to get near this one if I can. I had a particularly bad experience with the Emperor of Sands in Chandrar. You know, the new one? He was quite objectionable and I had trouble dealing with him. Of course, *she* was worse now that I think of it...”

That was another odd statement that didn’t make sense unless you knew more about the Emperor of Sands. Zel shook his head.

“[Emperors] are none of my business. Goblin Lord, Necromancer—that’s all I’ll help you with. You want to deal with him, do it yourself.”

“Cheapskate.”

Zel grew exasperated.

“Don’t you have a Skill that controls other people? Use that on him. I’ve heard about you and your charmed words.”

“Believe me, I would if I could, but my Skill is not powerful enough to sway anyone with a powerful class—or strong will. I’ve learned that the hard way recently.”

Magnolia made a face, which surprised Zel.

“I would have thought a high-level [Lady] would have more persuasion Skills than that.”

“Oh, *Skills*. I have lots of those, but charming others isn’t a vital Skill for me by any means. I have Skills in far more useful areas, I’m pleased to say.”

“Such as?”

She clicked her tongue dismissively.

“Skills that boost the welfare and safety of my lands, Skills that help me train servants, protect myself, manage my estates...”

“And your highest-level Skill?”

Magnolia Reinhart hesitated and eyed Zel for a second.

“Why do you want to know?”

He shrugged.

“We are allies. It’s helpful to know what your best Skill is. I’m sure you know mine.”

“Hmm...I suppose so. Very well. My highest-level Skill is [Aegis of Grace].”

“I’m unfamiliar with it.”

“Not surprising. It’s a powerful Skill that extends across my lands. To simplify, it wards off attack from any settlement affiliated with me. Thus, my mansion, Invril, and other holdings deter casual [Bandits], monsters, and other unsavory groups from attacking them. Attacks do occur of course, but that is one of the reasons why Invril has grown so prosperous of late. Adventurers do their bit, but my Skill—and the reputation I have worked so hard to dismay you with—also protects my people.”

Was that a joke? Zel blinked and nodded. Magnolia smiled at him.

“It may not seem like much considering your Skills can literally turn the tide of battle, but I suspect one of the reasons why all these Goblins have been raiding other settlements and cities is due to that Skill. After all, peace brings prosperity and with enough money I can do a great deal.”

“I can appreciate that. Thank you for telling me.”

Zel nodded to Magnolia. She dipped her head graciously, and then put down her empty cup and stood up.

“Well, I do believe that was a profitable little talk. However, I think that you and I have gone over...most of the points we wished to discuss. You aren’t beholden to me, and I am your ally of circumstance. For now.”

Her eyes twinkled and Zel suspected she planned to turn him into an ally for good. But he made no comment, simply rising to his feet.

“I’m fine with that. If you’ll show me the way, I’ll finish assessing my army and sending out instructions—”

“Oh psht. That can wait. Reynold and Sacra are very good at their jobs and I have something for you. I was going to give it to you tomorrow, but I suppose that since we’re tentative allies, now is the best time. You do need to know what you’re working with, after all. Follow me.”

Magnolia was either a night owl or she'd had far too much sugar, because she strode towards the doors and down the hallway at a brisk pace. Zel followed, his legs and tail almost asleep. Magnolia led him down a flight of stairs, through a hallway full of [Maids] and [Servants] who stared at Zel, past a Gnoll [Maid]—

“A Gnoll [Maid]?”

Zel had to take a step back to look at that. Magnolia walked back to him as he saw a Gnoll [Maid] serving a plate of food to a man dressed all in black in a small sitting room. Both Gnoll and Human glanced up and froze as they saw Zel peeking in. He turned away and saw Magnolia and Ressa peeking as well.

“Oh, don't mind her. Bekia's been in my service for years. As for the rather young and nervous [Assassin] there—that's Theofore.”

“Theofore?”

Zel looked blankly at the [Assassin], who'd gone pale at the sight of a famous Drake [General]. Zel tried to remember what the open bounty on his head was and forgot. He'd gutted more than one [Assassin] after his life, which was probably why the young man was so afraid. Magnolia nodded sympathetically.

“A young fool. I have some...trouble with the Assassin's Guild, and he was blindingly unaware of the entire affair. Suffice it to say he's marked for death by his own guild, which is why I'm letting him stay here. Rather charitable of me I know, but I suppose I'll need at least one [Assassin] once I'm done cleaning up.”

Both Zel and Theofore eyed Magnolia as she turned away. The [General] followed Magnolia into the main hallway, and then, to his surprise, out of the doors and into the garden.

“Why are we going out here?”

“Oh, don’t worry—I keep my estate’s weather controlled by magic.”

Magnolia reassured Zel without answering the question as she strolled out into a pleasant, cool night that was at odds with the dour wet cold of the fleeing winter outside of her mansion. Zel followed her into a veritable labyrinth of hedges, flowers, and trees, staring at a giant cloud floating very low overhead.

“You have a lot of magic in your mansion.”

“Yes, don’t I? I collect it. Mind the ground—looks like the cloud’s just been through. Oh, and Ressa, do make sure it doesn’t shoot lightning by accident, will you? I’d hate for anything to strike our [General], especially as he is wearing armor.”

Zel eyed the passing raincloud warily and walked a few steps away from it. Magnolia was preoccupied, however. She walked through a hedge maze, calling out loudly.

“Nalthal! Nalthaliarstrelous! Please don’t make me call your full name again! Where are you?”

There was a rustle and Zel turned and saw a dour-looking old man in dirty robes appear out of the hedges like a dirty, scruffy ghost. Unlike every other servant in Magnolia’s employ, he was not professional, did not bow to her when he appeared, and instead leaned on the hoe he was carrying and glared at Magnolia, Ressa, and Zel all at once.

He made the Drake’s scales prickle. Magnolia smiled as she greeted Nalthal, her [Gardener]. The old man grunted as she approached.

“Nalthal, I do apologize for the late hour, but I was hoping you had my two you-know-whats around here? In the maze perhaps? And I’ll need the rest of the artifacts my grandfather gave me.”

The old [Gardener] grunted and eyed Zel. The [General] felt his scales prickle again and took two steps backwards. Magnolia frowned.

“Oh please, General. Nalthal doesn’t smell *that* bad. Although I do agree he is rather...pungent.”

“It’s not that. I’m just getting out of his range.”

Zel folded his arms and stared hard at the ‘gardener’. He noticed Ressa was also standing away from the old man. Nalthal muttered something incomprehensible and scratched at one armpit. Magnolia looked at him and then at Zel and her eyes widened.

“Oh! Warrior’s instincts, is it? Ressa hates standing near Nalthal too. Although that may be the smell again...Nalthal, I do appreciate your display of animosity, but my grandfather’s things?”

He grunted irritably at her. Unperturbed, she poked him and he shuffled off through the hedge maze. Ressa brought up the rear and Zel kept narrowing his eyes at the [Gardener]’s back. There was definitely a field around him that Zel didn’t want to enter. He looked at Ressa as the [Maid] frowned at Nalthal’s back.

“Excuse me. Miss Ressa. That [Gardener] is a warrior, isn’t he?”

Ressa nodded shortly.

“He is. Although he’s no warrior, but rather a mage.”

“Really? What kind?”

“[Druid].”

Zel paused. He looked around at the garden, and realized it was not so much a beautifully tended delight of flowers, but an infestation of greenery just barely curtailed from overgrowing the mansion.

“And she lets him tend her gardens?”

Ressa’s face said it all. Nalthal, the dangerously irritable [Druid], led them through the maze and several twists and turns. It didn’t seem that protected, but Magnolia explained to Zel as he walked.

“You see, I had a break-in last month...terrible business and I have some rather powerful artifacts here, so I decided to place them with Nalthal. I do have a treasury, but some of the items are ah, rather large and Nalthal is quite good at his job. I believe his shrubbery ate two [Assassins] when they attacked. Oh, here we are!”

“*Ancestors!*”

Zel roared and nearly dove out of the way as he rounded a bend in the maze and came face-to-face with a giant metal monster. A Golem, a monster with knives for hands and a huge metal body inscribed with runes and armored like a Dullahan, stared down at him. A glowing white light shone from its mouth—it had no head, just a giant opening which was its mouth and eyes and face all at once.

It was huge. And it was one of a pair. The second battle Golem loomed over Zel, a mass of metal and magic that shone with inactivated spells and deadly intent. The [General] backed up fast from the two Golems, staring at Magnolia.

“Dead gods, are those *War Golems*? Where did you get these things from?”

“Oh, the Reinhart family vaults of course. I have a grandfather—whom I would very much like to kill if you and Niers do agree to join me—who has a few lying about. I thought they would be a fine addition to the army. They certainly are good at killing things.”

Magnolia twinkled at Zel. She walked over to the hulking War Golems without fear. That was more than Zel could do—his heart was beating out of his chest as he recalled stories of how War Golems would wade through armies leaving a trail of death in their wakes.

Ressa clearly had heard the same stories, because she was eying the huge metal monsters with the same trepidation. Both War Golems were over twelve feet tall and were more than a match for any monster they encountered. Only Nalthal's overgrown hedge maze could have hidden them. The [Druid] seemed unimpressed with the War Golems as well. He kicked one and walked around it, muttering as Magnolia explained.

"I requisitioned some soldiers from my estate as well. They're already at the meeting place—oh dear, I hope they have food—well, I'm sure they'll be fine. They're [Knights], and [Mages]. A small force and they don't see combat much, but they are well equipped."

"And the two War Golems? They're for *me*?"

Zel stared upwards, scarcely able to believe a relic from the past would be put under his command so easily. If he'd had both of them before, Ilvriss would have thought twice about attacking him. Any army would. A War Golem was worth at least a thousand soldiers used correctly. Ancestors, no wonder Magnolia Reinhart could speak about creating a perfect army! Give him a hundred War Golems and he'd take down a Walled City!

Well, maybe not a Walled City, but anything up to that point—Zel's mind spun with the possibilities of how he'd use them in battle. He wondered what a [Strategist] would make of them.

Magnolia smiled, and then turned as she saw Nalthal dragging something across the ground. She cried out in dismay.

"Oh come now Nalthal! That's not the way to treat General Shivertail's armor!"

“My what?”

Zel looked over and saw Magnolia fussing over a huge and clearly magical breastplate. She couldn't lift it herself, so Ressa and Nalthal had to pick it up. It was dirty, but the dirt couldn't hide the impressive nature of the armor. The golden-red metal *shone* in the dark night, and seemed to blaze as if a flickering fire was right in front of the armor. Nalthal sneered at it and nearly dropped his end until Ressa kicked him.

“This is a set of armor from the Reinhart vaults, General Shivertail. I selected it myself. It's a powerful artifact and—”

“It's stolen.”

Zel folded his arms. Magnolia blinked and broke off.

“Excuse me?”

The Drake [General] glared at Magnolia and Ressa alike. He pointed to the armor with a trembling claw.

“I recognize that armor! That is the Heartflame Breastplate, one of my people's national treasures! We thought it was lost after General Ironscales was slaughtered and her corpse disappeared two centuries ago—you Humans had it this entire time?”

“Oh dear. Did we Ressa?”

“Probably.”

The [Maid] shrugged and glared at Nalthal as he dropped his end of the armor and stomped away. She offered it to Zel unapologetically.

“The Reinharts steal everything. Regis Reinhart acquired it and we had no idea it was in his possession until we asked. It's yours now.”

“Mine?”

Zel stared at Magnolia in disbelief. He lifted the breastplate gingerly in his claws. It was indeed heavy, but if legends were true, it could stop an enchanted lance thrust to the heart without a problem. Magnolia smiled at him as the Drake looked at her in disbelief.

“Of course! The Golems are here to protect you and the breastplate should help you in battle if it’s that famous an artifact. I’m hardly one to be stingy with my wealth, General Shivertail, and you deserve to have as many artifacts as one of the Lords of the Wall in your Walled Cities.”

“And wear a hundred rings and amulets at all times? Hardly. But I will take this armor. I don’t need enchanted gear, but this—”

It was like he was a small child again and being given an actual magic sword. Zel’s claws trembled as he unbuckled his breastplate. Once upon a time Sserys had ordered a set of magical armor made for Zel and he had refused. He didn’t need armor thanks to his Skills. But this?

When Zel stood, his armor burned on his chest and he felt warm, stronger. Magnolia clapped her hands in delight and Ressa carefully wiped some dirt off of the gleaming enchanted metal. Zel looked at her and felt conflicted.

“You have a thousand magical artifacts, Reinhart. Countless secrets, powerful servants, and more wealth than I can dream of. How is it that you haven’t taken over this continent already?”

The Deadly Flower of the North smiled at Zel and he thought she looked rueful. Just for a second.

“Honestly? Because money cannot buy everything, Zel Shivertail. I have artifacts, yes. Money, yes. Servants? Oh, they are strong, but they are not champions. The Goblin King swept through these lands because he was mighty. I am a [Lady], not a warrior, General Shivertail. To back up my

charming words and wealth, I need a sword, an army. Do you see why I approached you?”

“I do. But I’m sorry to say—”

“Yes, yes. You’re not my sword. Not yet.”

Magnolia waved a hand, looking put out. Zel grinned. He opened a claw and looked up at the War Golems.

“I was *going* to say that you don’t have a sword. I’m a defensive [General]. If you want offense, get the Titan or bring back Sserys. I hold the line. Occasionally I charge into the enemy and redefine the line, but I’m best suited defending. You have a shield, Reinhart.”

She looked at him, her lips pursed, hands on hips.

“I know that I should appreciate that statement as it is, but a shield hardly sounds useful for dealing with a Goblin Lord.”

“No? You can give me one and I’ll beat him to death with it.”

Zel grinned and flexed his claws. He felt ready for a battle. The Goblin Lord might have an army, but Zel did too. Probably. And he had two War Golems, magic armor, and...well, that was about it. He just needed his claws and he’d tear a hole in that Goblin Lord’s chest.

At least, he hoped he would. In the worst case he might have to avoid a battle. It depended on the Goblin Lord’s army and how strong they’d be when Zel’s forces met him. Forty thousand soldiers was good, but the [General] hadn’t lived as long as he had by taking stupid risks. You took stupid risks only when you had no other choice.

“Well, I think I’ve got a few more things to think on. Lady Reinhart, shall we return to your mansion? I have a battle to plan.”

Magnolia smiled at him.

“Call me Magnolia, will you? And I will call you Zel. After all, we are allies and, I hope, friends.”

Zel stared at her. Magnolia smiled. He coughed.

“No. We’re not friends.”

“What?”

Her smile vanished. Zel shuffled his feet. Ressa snorted.

“We’re not friends, Reinhart. I still don’t trust you.”

“Oh come now!”

She tried to grab his arm and he walked away. Magnolia sighed loudly.

“We are allies! Comrades-in-arms! I gave you that armor!”

“You can’t even lift my armor.”

“I am *trying* to be friendly.”

“You don’t have to be. We’re allies, not bedfellows.”

“This is really distressing me, Zel. I felt we had reached an understanding, a connection.”

“Don’t call me that, please.”

“Zel—”

“I’m going back to the mansion.”

“Fine! *Unbelievable*. Stubborn Drakes. Ressa, let’s go.”

“Okay.”

“Right. We’re off. General Shivertail? Which way are—”

“I don’t know. Which way’s the way out?”

“Of course it’s that—no, I suppose not. Or this way? Hm. Nalthal! Which way is...Nalthal?”

The two Humans and Zel looked around. The [Druid] turned [Gardener] did not reply as Magnolia called his name. They looked around and realized they were lost in the hedge maze, between towering thick walls of greenery that were at least sixteen feet high. Now that Zel really thought about it, you could probably die in a maze. He looked at Magnolia. Ressa looked at Magnolia. Magnolia looked around and sighed.

“I hate my [Gardener].”

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The hour was late. Across the continent of Izril, it was nighttime. Of course, in Baleros it was morning and Kenjiro was awake and negotiating the cost of paper with Xalandrass the Naga. In Chandrar, it was just past midday and Trey was ‘sparring’ with Gazi, which mainly meant her kicking him about until he couldn’t move.

But things were happening everywhere. Meetings of note were occurring. In Magnolia Reinhart’s personal estate, the famous [Lady] was ordering her two War Golems to blast a hole in a walled hedge maze. And while the ensuing battle between Ressa, Zel, and an enraged [Druid] gardener might have been amusing to witness (if not experience), other important conversations were happening. Cakes were being thrown.

And that was the thing. Despite its subpar nature as a weapon of war, cakes had the unparalleled value of both comedic effect and surprise on their side. They could start a fight or, in this case, halt one. Fragments of the large cake Erin had made dripped off of Ylawes’ armor and onto the ground, a capital waste of sugar. But it had stopped him from charging at the Redfang Goblins.

This was the scene. Ylawes stood in the open doorway of Erin’s inn, sword drawn and shield raised. He’d been struck by a flying cake—mainly because it hadn’t registered as a threat until too late. Even though he was frosted, he was still eying the Redfang Warriors warily. And they had recognized him.

All five of the Redfang Warriors were on their feet, holding their weapons. Badarrow was aiming an arrow at Ylawes’ chest, but they weren’t attacking. Rather, they were frozen.

Around the room, the other adventurers were also on their feet. The Halfseekers were eying the Goblins and the Horns of Hammerad were eying the new adventurers. Yvlon's face was pale. Ceria was blinking as she stared at the other half-Elf standing behind Ylawes. Pisces was fighting with Mrsha and Ksmvr over a slice of cake. Everyone else was waiting for everyone else to make the first move.

Lyonette stared as Erin sat back down at her table. The [Innkeeper] looked around, seemingly satisfied with her handiwork.

“See, this is why you always bake *three* cakes. Ishkr, go get me another.”

That broke the silence. Ishkr blinked as half the eyes shifted to him, and then one of the new adventurers began to laugh. The Dwarf, standing by Ylawes' side, started chuckling and then guffawing loudly.

He did it well. Erin had never heard a proper guffaw, but the Dwarf was so boisterous, so unashamedly loud and amused that it broke the tension. By his side, the half-Elf lowered her staff with a sigh and Ilvriss sat up. The Wall Lord eyed the new adventurers and looked at Erin.

“Is your inn always like this, Human?”

She began to laugh as well. The room relaxed. Jelaqua began to laugh, Moore covered his mouth with one hand, and Seborn sat down. Only Ylawes, the Goblins, and Yvlon remained tense. The [Knight] in caked armor stared suspiciously at the Goblins and then at Yvlon. He called out sharply.

“Yvlon! What are Goblins doing here? Get behind me—”

“Ylawes—”

It was clear that Yvlon and Ylawes were related, and not just from their names. Ylawes' hair was a darker blonde, but they both had fair features

and a certain angular and European cast to their faces. Mainly though, it was the way they dressed. Both wore silvery armor—although Yvlon’s was more mismatched due to it being a collection of enchanted armor—and their eyes were both light blue.

Yvlon looked at her older brother helplessly, stunned by his sudden appearance. Ylawes was more focused on the Goblins, though. He held his sword and shield grimly, ready for a fight.

“Why are Goblins—”

“They’re guests, Ylawes. Can’t you tell?”

The half-Elf standing behind him interrupted Ylawes by tapping him on the shoulder with her staff. He turned his head, disbelieving.

“Impossible. Goblins in an inn? That has to be—”

“Why else would they be here? Besides, there’s a sign.”

Erin stopped laughing and sat up as the half-Elf informed Ylawes coolly. The [Knight] hesitated.

“A sign?”

The half-Elf woman sighed loudly. She nodded to the open door, which was letting in cold night air. Erin was tempted to ask them to shut the door, but she didn’t want to interrupt.

“It says ‘No Killing Goblins’ on the sign outside, Ylawes. Didn’t you read it? You were warned.”

“It does?”

The [Knight] turned in astonishment. The Dwarf by his side snorted and Ylawes looked down.

“Just like a Human not to notice what’s at his feet! Well, what now, lad? Are you going to break some skulls and break the rules or sheathe that sword before it gets rusty?”

Ylawes hesitated, looking around the room. It was tense—the Redfang Goblins were all clearly ready for a fight, and the other adventurers were tense. Maybe they weren’t on the Goblins’ side, but the sight of Moore peering at you with his massive staff held in one hand...he was such a considerate, gentle soul, but he could also push a thumb through your face if he chose.

After a second, Ylawes sheathed his sword. Erin smiled broadly and stood up.

“You read the sign! No one reads the sign! For that you get a free drink! On the house!”

The new adventures looked at her. The Dwarf tugged at his thick beard and spoke with a deep, booming voice.

“Free drinks? Hah! Maybe coming all this way was worth it after all! I’ll have five mugs to start with and whatever you’re eating. That thing you hit Ylawes with will do to start with.”

He stumped across the inn and took a seat at the nearest table. Erin blinked at him.

“Wait, I said free drink. You have to pay for the others...”

“This inn serves Goblins?”

The [Knight] addressed Erin, still peering at the Goblins. They’d sat themselves back down the instant he sheathed his sword. Badarrow and Rabbiteater made expressive gestures at the armed warrior from their seats. Erin only smiled.

“That’s right. Welcome to the Wandering Inn! You get a drink on the house for reading the sign—*one free drink.*”

“I heard you!”

The Dwarf shouted back. He was waving at Ishkr. Ylawes opened his mouth, probably to ask the obvious questions Erin normally got, but he broke off as he looked at his feet. Something white and furry was circling his armored boots. Mrsha had snuck forwards and was greedily stuffing the remains of the cake into her mouth. Lyonette cried out.

“Mrsha, *no!* That’s disgusting! Stop that!”

The Gnoll looked up completely unashamed, frosting covering her face. She bolted as Lyonette came towards her with a mop and the [Princess] chased after the Gnoll. Ylawes followed them for a few seconds, blinking, and then looked at Erin again.

“Your inn serves Goblins?”

“Yup! And you are...?”

She stared at him expectantly. Ylawes worked his jaw for a few seconds, and then recovered and bowed slightly.

“Pardon me, Miss. Ylawes Byres at your service. I lead the Silver Swords, an adventuring group dedicated to fighting monsters. I am a [Knight], and as such, offer you my sword and shield if you should ever be in need.”

His eyes flicked to the Redfang Goblins as he spoke. Erin smiled at him.

“Hi. I’m Erin. I don’t think I’ll need your sword and shield, but I guess I’ll ask if I’m in trouble. I’m an [Innkeeper]. Sorry about throwing the cake at you.”

Again, Ylawes found himself at a loss for words, so Erin relented a bit and dropped a bit of her oblivious act. She briskly nodded to the Redfang Warriors.

“I serve Goblins at my inn, Mister Ylawes. They don’t cause trouble and I don’t let people stab them with swords. If you don’t like that you can leave—although it seems like you know Yvlon. Are you two related?”

“I’m her brother. I’ve been searching for her for weeks—you truly let Goblins come in and out all the time?”

He really seemed to be having a hard time getting over the entire idea of Goblins, or at least, Goblins as guests. Erin frowned at Ylawes, but the half-Elf by his side came forwards next.

“Please excuse my companion, Miss Erin. We will abide by your rules so long as we remain at the inn. Allow me to introduce myself. I am Falene Skystrall. At your service.”

“Oh!”

Erin blinked at the half-Elf and took her in for the first time. She had light red hair, unearthly features like Ceria, but where the two half-Elves differed was age and bearing. Ceria was down-to-earth when you got to know her. Whereas this half-Elf was clearly older and conducted herself with the grace and dignity that Erin ascribed to typical stories about Elves. As Falene introduced herself she bowed elegantly and made a complicated gesture with her left hand. Erin bowed back awkwardly, feeling clumsy compared to the half-Elf.

“Uh—uh, hi! Welcome to my inn.”

“Thank you. Allow me to apologize for Ylawes’ actions. We do not often meet Goblins that aren’t openly hostile...although it seems like this

month is the exception to that rule. I am also surprised to meet another of my kin. Greetings, sister.”

She looked towards Ceria as she said that. The other half-Elf was staring at her. Falene made another gesture with her hands and bowed again to Ceria.

Ceria nodded and didn’t bow or make any gestures with her hands.

“Uh, I’m Ceria Springwalker. Pleased to meet you...sister.”

Falene’s eyebrows rose slightly. She looked at Ylawes and nudged the [Knight] again with her staff.

“I believe that concludes our introductions. Ylawes, you might want to ask for a towel and some water to wipe yourself off...then you can speak with your sister. As for myself, I believe I’ll enjoy my drink.”

“It’ll take more than that to clean all that cake off.”

Erin felt a bit bad for Ylawes, splattered as he was with drying frosting. Falene eyed Ylawes and nodded.

“True. Well, this should get most of it off.”

She raised her staff and tapped Ylawes on the breastplate. There was a loud knocking sound and then the frosting and cake stuck to his armor, face, and hair immediately dried and fell to the ground. Erin whistled, and Falene nodded in satisfaction. She followed the Dwarf to the table as Ishkr hurried back with a few drinks.

Ylawes looked around, at a loss for a few seconds. Then he grimaced.

“This is not how I envisioned finding my sister.”

He stomped after his two teammates and sat at the table. Erin looked around. Mrsha was running about wildly on a sugar high, Ksmvr was eyeing the remains of the cake on the ground, Pisces was licking his fingers, and

Ceria was staring at Falene with a frown. The Halfseekers were pointing at the Silver Swords and clearly about to wander over and introduce themselves, Ishkr and Drassi were busy getting more food from the kitchens, and Ilvriss was looking around, discontented that no one was paying attention to him.

Erin sighed. Another day at the inn. She smiled, and grabbed Mrsha as the Gnoll ran past. She handed the wriggling Gnoll to Lyonette and shooed Apista away from the faerie flowers. She took three flower bulbs and squeezed them lightly, flicking the nectar into a mug. And then she got to work.

Getting to know people.

Ylawes Byres had come here to meet Yvlon Byres. He sat with his sister, talking quietly in a corner once he'd been served a deflated soufflé. Erin had to apologize for that.

"I guess my food preservation skill doesn't save them from gravity. And I just made them today! Oh well. I've got pizza and lots of other food if you want it."

"I'm grateful for the food, Miss Erin. We've been travelling for days now, and our last proper meal was as we were passing through Remendia. There was scarce food to be had in Esthelm as it was."

Ylawes assured Erin as he poked at the sad soufflé with a fork. At another table, the Dwarf spoke up loudly.

"Not to mention you had to give half our dinner away! If we hadn't arrived at Liscor tonight, I'd have eaten *you*, lad."

Erin grinned, and Ylawes twisted in his seat to glare at the Dwarf.

“You’re barely a decade older than me, Dawil.”

“So? I’m a Dwarf. You’re a Human brat. I can call you lad if I want.”

The half-Elf sitting at the table raised her elegant brows and looked reprovably at both of her companions.

“Which you only do when you’re trying to be aggravating. Let Ylawes talk with his sister, Dwarf. Or have you forgotten I’m older than both of you combined?”

“I hadn’t forgotten, grandmother.”

The Dwarf grinned to himself for all of five seconds until Falene tapped him on the head with her staff. He roared in outrage as the dark brown hair on his head began to smolder and doused the flames with his free drink. Falene stood up to walk over to Ceria as Dawil hurled his mug at her back. It flew towards her head then froze and gently floated onto another table. The Dwarf returned to his table, muttering about half-Elves who couldn’t take jokes.

The Silver Swords, the new adventuring group, were spread around the room now and Erin dearly wanted to listen to the conversations all three adventurers started. She was extremely interested in them all, not least because they were an almost stereotypical group of adventurers. A half-Elf, a Dwarf, and a Human? If a Hobbit walked through the door, Erin would have to get some autographs.

And it was the Dwarf that Erin was most interested in. He was focused more on food than conversation, and loudly calling for more drinks to go with the shepherd’s pie he’d been served. Erin was working out just how to approach him when Ksmvr did the job for her.

The Antinium had been instructed on some of the niceties of social conversation by the Horns of Hammerad. He demonstrated his learning in the subject now by grabbing his tankard and a half-eaten Ashfire Bee, standing up, walking over to where the Dwarf was seated, and sitting down across from him. The Dwarf looked up at the Antinium and stopped chewing.

“What?”

Ksmvr stared at the Dwarf intently. He raised one of his hands and waved it.

“Hello. I am Ksmvr.”

The Dwarf stared back at him. After a second he grunted and nodded.

“I’m Dawil. Of the Ironbreaker family.”

He took a long drink from his mug and eyed Ksmvr. After a second, Dawil spoke again.

“You’re one of them Ants, aren’t you? I thought you lot were all murderous killing machines without a thought between ye.”

“I am not. Although I appreciate the comparison.”

Ksmvr nodded happily. Dawil snorted and choked on his drink. He cast one eye around the room, taking in the half-Giant, Selphid, Drowned Man, Gnoll cub...when he returned to Ksmvr he shrugged, apparently resigned to the fact that an Antinium was talking to him.

“What’s that you’re eating? Some kind of bug?”

“It is an Ashfire Bee. Very tasty, especially with honey and butter. Would you like to try a bite?”

The Antinium nodded and lifted his plate so Dawil could see the bee. The Dwarf paused again, but the sight of the half-eaten bee didn't seem to put him off his food either.

“I don't eat bugs. Anyways. Isn't eating one of them bugs like eating your own kind?”

“Is it?”

Ksmvr paused as he broke off a bee leg. He thought about this as he crunched it down.

“No. Is eating a cow or a rat cannibalism for Humans or Dwarves?”

“It's disgusting is what it is. I don't eat rats.”

“No bugs, no rats...this is very sad. I see you are a Dwarf. Do all Dwarves not eat good food?”

Dawil snorted.

“Not unless we're starving to death we don't! I'd rather eat my beard than chew on insects like some half-Elf living in the forest.”

He shot that at Falene. The half-Elf raised her eyebrows.

“I don't eat bugs, Dawil. That's a stereotype about half-Elves. Hardly any of us resort to that.”

All of the Horns of Hammerad immediately looked at Ceria. The half-Elf [Cryomancer] coughed and looked the other way. Dawil laughed loudly and then broke off as something buzzed his way. He swatted at it and Apista flew away from his mug. The Dwarf stared at the insect with a mixture of horror and incredulity and then stared at Ksmvr. He pointed at Apista.

“Isn't that a bee as well? Why is *that* thing flying around?”

“It is a pet of Lyonette. She works here. It is called Apista and I think, very tasty. But she is off limits for consumption.”

Ksmvr sighed as Apista flew away from their table with his mandibles slightly parted in longing. Apista was noticeably larger than the Ashfire Bee that Ksmvr was eating. Dawil blinked at Ksmvr.

“A pet? By my beard...and you’re eating one of its kind right in front of it?”

Ksmvr stared at Apista. He slowly raised the bee to his mouth and crunched off another part.

“Yes. That is what I am doing.”

Over her time with Apista in the inn, Erin had noticed that while the Ashfire Bee would hover around sweet drinks and food when they weren’t being attended, it would never go within arm’s length of Ksmvr or any of the Antinium. Now the bee flew after Mrsha. The Gnoll was being carried upstairs by Lyonette, visibly upset and cranky after eating so much cake. Dawil watched the bee go with some relief and turned back to Ksmvr.

“This is one hell of an inn. I’ve been to magical taverns in First Landing and Invril and they’re *boring* compared to this inn. This [Innkeeper] girl—she just lets Goblins and Ants eat here and doesn’t worry about being killed in her sleep?”

“Oh no. Miss Erin is very good at killing things. And she employs one of my kind. His name is Bird and he lives on the roof. By the way, I have never met a Dwarf. Are you happy, being a Dwarf? Is there a special racial advantage to being a Dwarf or are you relatively useless like Humans?”

“Hey!”

Erin had to come over at that. She took a seat at the table and smiled at Dawil. He eyed her, probably wondering about Ksmvr’s endorsement of her

killing prowess. Erin smiled at Dawil, hesitated, and blurted out the first thing on her mind.

“You’re tall.”

The Dwarf blinked. Ksmvr tilted his head. Erin blushed.

“I mean—sorry, but I’ve never met a Dwarf either! And I didn’t expect you to be so, so...”

Tall. For a Dwarf, that was. Dawil grunted and sat up straight. He was a few inches over five feet in height, which was short for a Human, but far taller than Erin would have expected of a Dwarf. And he seemed amused by Erin’s interest.

“Hah! Not met many Dwarves, have you, girl? Oh wait. You said. Well, I’m a pure Dwarf, don’t you worry on that account! Pure as any Dwarf living, which I’ll grant isn’t what it used to be.”

He rumbled to himself as he took a huge spoonful of ground beef and potatoes and shoved it into his mouth. He chewed, swallowed, and then went on.

“Y’see, I’ve got a bit of Human blood in me. My great, great, great grandma, she was Human, and so was my great, great, great, great, great, great...uh, grampa. ‘Course, my Dwarf side’s too strong to let a bit of Human dilute my true ancestry, but over the years it mixes with our blood. Almost every Dwarf is a bit taller because of that. Not like how we used to be—short and yay-high!”

He gestured, indicating a height around four feet high. Erin nodded.

“That’s cool. Mixed heritage, I get that. I’m one hundred percent Human. My name’s Erin, by the way.”

“Right, I heard. Got ears, don’t I? And I already told the Antinium bugger my name. I’m not wearing it out.”

The Dwarf took another huge bite. He wasn’t rude—well, he was—but Erin wasn’t offended by it. He had a rather likable, straightforward personality in fact. Erin grinned at him.

“So you’re an adventurer in the Silver Swords?”

Dawil eyed her as he reached for his mug.

“Do you state the obvious all the time, lass? ‘Course I am! Hey, you don’t have anything stronger here, do you? I feel like I’m drinking water!”

“I have actual water if you want it—”

“*Hah!*”

“Okay then, how does Firebreath Whiskey sound? It’s the only strong stuff I have in stock right now. But it tastes like someone poured habaneros into a sock and mixed it with mouthwash.”

“Ah! A proper drink!”

Dawil brightened. He drained his mug in one go which impressed both Ksmvr and Erin and waved a hand at Ishkr.

“Firebreath Whiskey over here! Give me a full mug and another plate of the potatoes and meat!”

“One for me as well.”

Erin turned as Ksmvr tried to imitate Dawil and nearly drowned from his own mug. Ilvriss was sitting upright, looking annoyed at the lack of company and morose again. Erin intercepted Ishkr before he could deliver the Drake a drink.

“What’s the meaning of this?”

Ilvriss growled at Erin. She put her hands on her hips.

“No Firebreath Whiskey for you, Mister. You came here drunk and you had an entire mug of the stuff earlier. I’m cutting you off.”

The Lord of the Wall narrowed his eyes.

“You can’t cut me off. I am a *Lord of the Wall!*”

“Too bad. You can have this drink instead if you want. It’s a specialty of the inn. Faerie Flower ale. Here, try it. It makes you feel better. Or worse.”

Erin presented Ilvriss with the special mug she’d made. The Drake took one look at the drink and turned his head away.

“Ridiculous. I won’t settle for an inferior Human drink. If you refuse to serve me, I’m leaving. I have better places to be anyways—”

He moved to rise unsteadily. Erin barred his way and shoved the drink into his face.

“Try it. Come on. You tried the cake.”

“That was different. Wait, is this like the cake?”

Ilvriss eyed the mug again. The Faerie Flower ale was indistinguishable from regular ale...pretty much because it was. The only addition was three drops of the special faerie flower nectar Erin had added. She smiled encouragingly.

“You won’t know unless you try it.”

The Drake hesitated. He took the mug, grumbled about substandard alcohol, and took a gulp. His expression soured, and he was about to shove it back at Erin when his eyes widened. Erin took a few steps back as Ilvriss slowly sat back down.

“And now we wait.”

She muttered to herself as she walked back to Dawil's table. Erin hadn't forgotten Ilvriss' grief when talking about Periss. She only hoped the drink could do for him what it had for Halrac the first time the [Scout] had tried it.

"Oh, Halrac."

Erin had to pause and close her eyes for a second. The [Scout] hadn't shown his face in the inn since the night Ulrien had been cremated. But she could only take a moment of her time to think of him. At the table, Dawil was arguing with Ksmvr.

"What? Battle tactics? Strategic maneuvers? What do you think our group is? We're adventurers! We charge in and sort things out afterwards. I hit things with my hammer, Ylawes hits things with his sword, and Falene twiddles her fingers and shoots sparks at monsters while she hides behind our backs. It's a sound strategy!"

"It sounds like the exact opposite of strategy."

"Which is why it *works*! Now, what are you—Silver-rank? Dead gods, I didn't think there were Antinium adventurers. Well, never mind. What you do is, when you see a monster you run at it. Screaming."

"Screaming?"

"Yeah. A good old war cry. Then you hit it. Use a Skill if it's big, and if it's *really* big go for the kneecaps. That always works."

"What if it is a giant slime? Giant slimes do not have kneecaps. I point this out not as an attempt to be confrontational, but merely to question—"

"Slimes? What are you doing fighting *slimes*? That's when you get a [Mage] to handle the job!"

"But you said—"

“I know what I said! Remind me!”

“Kneecaps—”

“Well, if they had them, it would be a viable strategy!”

It was like watching a comedy duo in action, even better than when Pisces and Ksmvr did it. Erin hated to break up the fun, but she had to. She cleared her throat as she slid back into her seat. Dawil and Ksmvr looked at her expectantly.

“Sorry, but I had a thought. You’re the first Dwarf I’ve ever met, Dawil. I mean, I’ve seen half-Dwarves, but you’re the only full Dwarf I’ve ever seen.”

“Not surprising. My kind live mainly on Terandria and we don’t like traveling. Too much water and boats get us seasick.”

The Dwarf shuddered as he reached for a second plate of steaming shepherd’s pie. He had an incredible appetite, but then, he was very muscular and stocky. Erin smiled.

“Well, yeah. But I was thinking...I have this coin you see. It’s, well, sort of a mystery and no one can tell me what metal it’s made of. I was wondering...”

The Dwarf paused as she fished out the special coin she’d received. He eyed it, and then glared at Erin.

“What, do you think I know about metals just because I’m a *Dwarf*?”

He looked mildly outraged. Erin waved her hands frantically.

“Oh, no! No, it’s just—well, yes, actually. Sorry. I just thought that since you’re a Dwarf and uh...if you don’t know, that’s fine. But no one else I’ve talked to has a clue, so...”

The Dwarf grumbled into his beard, but then stuck out a hand.

“Alright, give it here then. Not like I’m a [Forgemaster], but I reckon I know a bit more than any Human or Drake [Blacksmith]...”

“Ooh. I probably should have asked one of them to look at it. Right. Oops.”

Dawil snorted as Erin handed him the coin. It flashed in the firelight as he held it up, not quite silver but pale, reflective. Ksmvr stared at it and the Dwarf grunted, his expression of annoyance growing more intrigued.

“Hold on, that’s not an alloy of silver...it’s got no silver in it in fact. And it’s no alloy. Wait a second...hey, innkeeper! Where’d you get this?”

Erin shrugged self-consciously as Dawil stared at her.

“Um...one of my guests gave it to me as payment. I mean, it was sort of a gift, not proper payment. Why? Is it worth a lot?”

The Dwarf grunted.

“Depends on how you look at it. It’s either priceless or worthless. You see, this metal’s not silver, gold, or any of your common metals like that. It’s pure mithril, or close enough.”

“Mithril?”

Erin’s raised voice made every head in the room shoot up. Quick as a flash, Jelaqua was at their table.

“Hey, did someone say mithril and Dwarf in the same sentence? I could really use a new flail and armor—”

“Back off, Selphid! No one’s forging you lot anything! I just said this thing’s mithril—no need to get worked up about it! Yes, this is mithril. So what?”

Dawil cleared his throat, realizing he had an audience. Seborn, Jelaqua, and an interested Ishkr were hovering around the table. He handed the coin back to Erin and she held it as if it were magic. Which it might be. The Dwarf was less impressed, though.

“What are you waiting for? The coin to start floating in midair? It’s mithril, I told you! It’s just a metal.”

“But it’s—I mean, it’s *mithril*!”

Images of mithril chainmail and magical artifacts were spinning around Erin’s head. Dawil shook his own head sadly.

“Pah. It’s just a bit. You couldn’t make anything out of it—not that I’d want to try. That’s why I said it’s worthless or priceless. Sure, it’s rare to find a coin made purely out of the stuff—I can’t think of how old it must be—but who’s going to want something like that? It’s got no real value except as a collector’s item.”

He was too casual about the coin. Erin held it, trying to feel something out of the metal. All she felt was a bit of stickiness from where some drink had landed on it.

“Still, I mean—shouldn’t it glow or something?”

“It might. Buff it up a bit and it could look better. The coin’s covered in dust and the outer layer’s bonded with enough crap over the centuries. Scrape at it and it might look better.”

Dawil conceded grudgingly. He looked at Jelaqua.

“What’re you looking at, Selphid?”

“You wouldn’t happen to be a [Blacksmith] as well as a warrior, by any chance?”

She looked at him hopefully. Dawil guffawed in her face.

“Me? Do I look like I enjoy sweating in front of a forge fire? Count me out!”

“It’s just that I really would like better gear. I have this flail you see—by the way, I’m Jelaqua Ivirith, leader of the Halfseekers—”

“Oh, I’ve heard of you. Dawil of the Ironbreaker Clan.”

“—right, pleased, and I’d really love some better gear. Seborn’s got enchanted daggers, but no one makes enchanted flails. And I’ve heard that you can get Dwarf-made weapons for cheap. I was told mithril might be a good buy...”

The Dwarf shook his head as Erin sat at the table, polishing her coin with a tankard of water. It didn’t seem to work. She scrubbed hard but concluded she might actually need to scrape at it with a knife or something. That wouldn’t hurt the mithril, right? Or the faint engravings? It was supposed to be hard stuff. Erin went to look for a butter knife. Meanwhile, Dawil was beginning to argue with Jelaqua about weapons.

“Mithril? It’s things like this that make me regret ever leaving home! Every two-bit adventurer comes up to me asking for a magical blade—do I look like I carry a forge around on my back? And aren’t you lot an experienced Gold-rank team? What are you asking *me* about weapons for? We’re a new Gold-rank team.”

“Sorry. But it’s just that we don’t meet many Dwarves, and you hear rumors. So mithril weapons...?”

“Eh. Steel’s just as good.”

“*What?* Aw, come on!”

The other adventurers looked at Erin. She was heartbroken, as if Dawil had just punched her in the stomach. She looked so downcast that the

Dwarf had to explain.

“It’s just like you beardless lot to think one metal’s best! Mithril? Hah! If you want lightweight armor, sure, use a mithril alloy. But making plate armor out of the stuff? Do you know what that would *cost*? Plus, mithril’s not all it’s worked up to be. Sure, it’s stronger than steel, but it’s too malleable—you need to cut it with a stronger alloy. Then of course it’s better than regular steel, but for the *cost*—and forget about putting it in a weapon!”

“Well, if it’s the cost—”

Jelaqua began but Dawil talked over her.

“Not just cost! Unless you’ve got the sharpest blade in existence, you’ll have no weight behind your blows! Mithril’s not worth its weight in gold! Now, a composite metal made by a master is more preferable.”

“Okay, but what kind—”

“Oh, you’ll hear the words ‘adamantium’ and ‘orichalcum’ and ‘star metal’ and so on thrown around a lot, but that’s all rock crap. *Real* [Blacksmiths] who aren’t trying to take your money will tell you that pure metals are useless on their own. What you want to be asking is what level of refinement they’ve achieved and *then* asking what kind of alloys they’ll be making with said rare metals. Eh...how much they have on hand is also a good idea. It’s rare stuff and you don’t want to be waiting months for a shipment to arrive.”

Erin saw Jelaqua open her mouth, but the Selphid couldn’t get a word in edgewise. The Dwarf kept going, as unstoppable as an avalanche. She realized that she might have opened a door she couldn’t close and resigned herself to listening as Dawil went on.

“If they tell you they can work in an adamantium alloy into your armor, well, they’re either lying or Level 50, because let me tell you, I can count the number of times I’ve seen *anything* with adamantium in it, and I grew up seeing the Old Elders about, and they can forge anything in the world. Not that you’d know it to look at them. Hah, real Dwarven smithing today is all about quality and efficiency. Take Dwarven steel for example. Good stuff will do you just as well as a fancy artifact, and let me tell you, if you want to order well, all you need to do is—”

Sitting and listening to Dawil, Ksmvr nodded repeatedly as the Dwarf kept talking. He was so focused that he didn’t notice Erin, Jelaqua, Seborn and Ishkr edging away from the Dwarf. Neither did Dawil. The Dwarf kept talking as he drank and ate, loudly proclaiming the virtues of metal for all to hear and managing to slip in several insults about Human and Drake craftsmanship while he was at it.

“It looks like Dawil’s started one of his rants about blacksmithing. It will be hours before he stops. For a Dwarf that hates blacksmithing, he enjoys lecturing others about it too much.”

At another table Falene Skystroll lightly observed her companion as she sipped from a cup of wine and cut into one of Erin’s pre-cooked steaks. She had been pleasantly surprised to find out how many different dishes were on the menu, and more surprised at how fast it had appeared. Now she ate with excellent manners, sitting in her chair across from Ceria. And Pisces.

The [Necromancer] had invited himself to the table after washing his hands of cake and neither half-Elf had chased him away. Ceria didn’t have the heart for it and Falene didn’t seem to mind. In truth, Ceria was slightly

grateful for Pisces' presence. She felt awkward in the company of another half-Elf after so long.

Especially since Falene had given her a very traditional, very old-fashioned greeting. She was clearly a traditionalist and she had to be at least eighty years old! True, she looked barely older than her late twenties, but Ceria knew there was a big shift in perspectives depending on the age of a half-Elf. They were half-Human after all, and like Humans, they changed far more rapidly than their distant ancestors had.

"I hope Dawil doesn't talk your companion's ears off."

"He doesn't have ears, so he'll be fine. I think Ksmvr's the only person who'd actually enjoy a lecture like that."

Ceria grimaced. Falene raised two eyebrows at her, the model of composure. Ceria bit the inside of her lip. Yup, definitely a traditionalist. Falene was the kind of half-Elf who tried to act like she thought true Elves had. That was to say, always graceful, always elegant, and the voice of logic and reason within any group. You'd never catch *her* squatting in the bushes after eating something that didn't agree with her system.

And she was also a [Mage]. A good one—Ceria could tell that just from sitting next to her. Falene had an air of control and power about her that Ceria hadn't sensed in anyone since Wistram. Well, Typhenous and Moore were powerful too, but there was something about her magical presence that was familiar...

"I am surprised to meet a fellow half-Elf so far from Terandria, sister. Especially in the company of one of the Antinium. That is unheard of. It must have been quite a set of coincidences that landed you in each other's company."

Ceria blinked as Falene addressed her. She waited for a beat, and then shrugged.

“Yeah?”

What was she supposed to say to that? Half-Elves went places. So did Humans. Falene smiled.

“I don’t mean to judge. But it is strange—my party has travelled very, very far in search of Ylawes’ sister. We came all the way to Celum to look for her, then took a detour in Esthelm before heading north again...who would have thought all we had to do was go further south to find her?”

Ceria grunted.

“You could have spared yourself the trip. There’s a magical door that leads straight from Celum to Liscor. You can walk between the cities whenever you want now.”

The other half-Elf’s eyebrows shot up and she cast a glance at the door.

“So *that’s* what I was sensing from that door. Incredible. I had no idea a magical artifact that powerful had been found. And it’s sitting in an inn? Is this [Innkeeper] that high-level? I didn’t get the impression...”

She was being chatty with Ceria, as if they were friends. Just because they were of the same species. That bothered Ceria...mainly because it was a very typical half-Elven thing to do. Forget Drakes—half-Elves were notoriously insular. And if you were of the same species, you naturally stuck up for one another.

But then—they had to. Ceria sighed. She was just being irritable on purpose. After the news about Calruz and—well, it was hard to meet someone who was like you in many respects but more accomplished. She cleared her throat, trying to adopt a more civil tone.

“No, Erin’s not *that* high-level, although she’s pretty high. Uh...the door’s there because we gave it to her. My team found it in the Ruins of Albez.”

“Albez—you’re the famous Horns of Hammerad we’ve heard about?”

Ceria and Pisces both coughed and looked away as Falene exclaimed. Pisces looked pleased and Ceria felt pleased and embarrassed.

“That’s us. We got lucky, honestly. We’re a Silver-rank team—hoping to be Gold-rank soon. That door was one of the treasures we obtained you see, and we owe Erin a lot, so it was her take of the treasure...”

Falene listened with interest to Ceria’s account of the events that had led them to salvaging the door from Albez. Adventurers swapped stories as a matter of course, and Ceria was humble enough not to embellish. Especially because *she* had heard of the Silver Swords in passing, and they were an actually famous group. Most Gold-rank groups made a name for themselves, although Ceria usually only knew the names. Now she tried to recall any of the Silver Swords’ exploits and failed.

“I am quite impressed! And from what I can see, your group is rather unusual. Two out of four of your group are [Mages]...it’s usually the case where there’s only a lone [Mage] unless the adventuring team is quite large. I sometimes wish I had another magic user to help guard my companions.”

The half-Elf sighed and glanced at Ylawes, who was deep in conversation with Yvlon, and Dawil. Ceria glanced at Yvlon—the young woman seemed tense and not quite at ease. Falene noticed her glance.

“Don’t worry. Ylawes is merely concerned about his sister. When he heard her adventuring group had been destroyed in Liscor’s dungeon he insisted we head south right away. It’s taken us weeks to journey from Invrilisil.”

“That’s some commitment. I guess that’s family for you. But Yvlon seemed determined *not* to meet him. Do you know why that is?”

Falene sighed.

“I think Ylawes is intent on escorting Yvlon back to their home.”

“Ah.”

“Oh.”

Pisces looked up from his cup and glanced at Ylawes before raising his eyebrows at Ceria. She made a face at him—yes, she didn’t want that, but they were family! Falene looked between the two.

“I’m sure he won’t force her. Or if he does, Dawil and I can talk him out of it. Ylawes is stubborn as a boar, but he can be persuaded. Given time.”

Ceria nodded at Falene in appreciation.

“Seems like you’re a good team. That’s surprising. I’d never expect one of us to be travelling with a Dwarf. Given how much they don’t like us—”

“Bad blood. It’s not as if our animosity is recent. I was more surprised that a Human wanted to journey with me after Terandria. But Ylawes is an excellent leader, and not prejudiced against us in the least. A delightful change from home, wouldn’t you say?”

Falene glanced at Ceria and the half-Elf nodded reluctantly.

“Speaking of home...Pisces is from Terandria as well.”

“Oh, I apologize. I didn’t mean to assume. It’s just that it’s rare to meet Humans who don’t have at least a bit of mistrust of half-Elves. Especially if they’ve grown up in some of the kingdoms...allow me to introduce myself again. I’m a generalist [Mage], although I’ve recently achieved the [Battlemage] specialization in my class.”

Both of Pisces’ brows shot up and Ceria sat up a bit in her chair. The [Necromancer] coughed.

“That is impressive. You have quite the magical flair about you, Miss Falene. May I inquire as to where you studied?”

The half-Elf laughed.

“Why, Wistram of course! I graduated from the academy three decades ago. A lifetime by Human standards. But I remember it fondly, and I count myself privileged to have studied there. So many [Mages] are powerful, but lack the discipline Wistram provides. That half-Giant for instance. Moore? Such a lovely person, but his aura is unrefined. You two on the other hand...”

Falene broke off, glancing from Ceria and Pisces.

“Yes, you two have more focus to your mana flow. Are you students of Wistram, perhaps? Taking a sabbatical? That was all the fashion when I was learning.”

She couldn’t have known how her words would make Pisces and Ceria tense up. The two [Mages] exchanged a glance, and Ceria saw Pisces’ knuckles grow white on his mug. What should she say? There were so many things she could say that were lies and untruths—but would they hurt less than the truth?

She didn’t get a chance to decide. Pisces was the one who spoke. The [Necromancer] smiled, a slight glint in his eyes as he nodded at Falene.

“We are both from Wistram, indeed, Miss Falene. However, you mistake our natures. We are graduates, the two of us.”

Ceria held her breath as Falene blinked. She looked at Pisces and then at Ceria, and then she smiled.

“Hm. Are you? In that case, it seems like the standards have lowered quite a bit since when I last attended.”

Calmly, and quite oblivious to the reaction her words had caused, Falene gently levitated her cup of wine up to her lips and took a sip.

“You should have sent word to me immediately when you were injured. I would have come sooner, but there was a situation with a city—Esthelm. And we stopped to help villages along the way...you should have told me. I would have sent gold, hired a carriage to take you north—”

Ylawes and Yvlon sat at a table in the corner of the inn, removed from the discussions happening elsewhere. The Goblins sat forgotten at their table, watching Ceria and Pisces bristle with interest, their ears perking up as Dawil’s voice droned on. Ylawes ignored them. His only concern was for his little sister.

As for his little sister, she was not happy. Yvlon stared hard at her brother, trying not to envy the shining silver armor that had given his group their name, the family crest etched proudly on his armor and shield that identified him as a [Knight].

He was everything she aspired to be. Everything she dreamed of. But *he* was not who she wanted, not now. And yet here he was. He’d ridden here, hundreds of miles, to save his younger sister, to champion the weak and innocent. Like he always did. But she was neither weak nor innocent and Yvlon tried to tell her brother that in no uncertain terms.

“I didn’t tell you because it was my mistake, my weakness that got my team killed, Ylawes. And afterwards, I was adventuring with another team. We had our successes. We found treasure in *Albez*—”

“And you were injured for it. Your arms, Yvlon! Silver and steel, I’m glad mother didn’t hear of it! All the family knew was that you’d taken

some injury that couldn't be healed by a potion."

Yvlon closed her eyes, remembering the burning heat that had raced up her arms, the pain, the *melting* and then—

"Yeah. But I got this injury protecting my team. I'd do it again in a heartbeat."

"And I'm proud of you for that. But see reason, Yv! We have to get you north. There's bound to be a [Healer] who can help mend your arms."

"There isn't. The metal's in my bones, Ylawes."

"Even so. A [Mage], perhaps? Money's no obstacle. I have a small fortune and I'm sure father and mother know many people we could reach out to. We'll have to wait a while for the Goblin Lord's army to pass by, but we can send word at once and begin asking—"

"I'm not going, Ylawes."

Ylawes broke off, staring at his sister in disbelief. Yvlon shook her head.

"I'm not going back home. Not yet. I have too much to do here. I'm in a team!"

It took her brother a second to find his voice, and when he did, it was angry.

"Don't be ridiculous, Yvlon! You can't fight with those injuries! With your arms the way they are, any prolonged battle will risk you breaking them again. Or worse! One good blow will—"

"I know that! But so what? I'm not going to be flailing around trading blows with my enemies, Ylawes! I have a sword with the weight enchantment applied to it—a better sword than the one you have! I can

fight, even if my arms are weaker than they were. If they break, I'll heal them—Pisces can repair the bones!”

Yvlon pointed towards Pisces, neglecting to mention the [Necromancer]’s class. It didn’t matter. Ylawes had changed tactics. His voice was soothing now as he stroked at the stubble on his chin.

“Of course you’re right to be proud. A magical sword at your age? Father will be so happy when he hears. But be reasonable, Yvlon! You should at least have a rest, or visit our estate. A month of rest and we can go adventuring together. I’m sure your companions won’t mind—why not ask them to come with you? There’s sure to be enough requests around our home to—”

“I said *no*.”

Yvlon snapped the word loudly, making heads turn in the mostly empty inn. She tried to calm herself.

“Ylawes, I appreciate that you were concerned. But—couldn’t you have asked if I was well before coming all this way to help me? I’m a grown woman, and you don’t need to worry about me. Honestly, I’m as fine as anyone is in this profession.”

The [Knight] looked troubled as he looked at his younger sister.

“Are you, Yvlon? I had to plot a huge course around the Goblin Lord’s army on the way south, Yvlon. And before that—I clashed with one of his raiding armies. They’d already sacked a city and they were coming back to slaughter all of its inhabitants and turn them into undead. This Goblin Lord’s a true threat, Yvlon. I’d heard the Goblins were dangerous, but using the undead? There was one skeleton I met in Esthelm that—”

He broke off, shaking his head. Ylawes turned back to Yvlon.

“I can only hope the army being assembled to the north will be enough to destroy the Goblin Lord and his army completely. I would have ridden myself in answer to Lord Tyrion’s call, but father sent enough forces from our household that will do. I hope. But that just proves my point. You’re in more danger around Liscor—there are Antinium here! Have you any idea what—”

He hadn’t realized Ksmvr was in her party. Yvlon closed her eyes, and then part of what Ylawes had said struck her like lightning. She sat up, cutting her brother off.

“Wait a second, we sent aid to Lord Tyrion? But Lady Magnolia was levying all the city-states around Invrisil!”

Ylawes frowned.

“You hadn’t heard? Lady Reinhart sent out a levy, true, but Lord Tyrion did the same. We sent reinforcements to him—as many [Soldiers] and [Guards] as father thought we could afford.”

Yvlon stared at her brother in horror.

“What? Not to Lady Magnolia? Ylawes, House Byres has *always* supported the Reinharts! Aunt Magnolia is a close friend of mother’s!”

“I know.”

“So why—”

It wasn’t so much what Ylawes said as the way he said it. His gaze shifted and he didn’t exactly meet Yvlon’s eyes as he spoke. She sat, heart pounding as he replied softly.

“Recent events have called her authority into question. There were several assassinations—of [Ladies] tied to Magnolia no less! Father was worried that...well, it doesn’t matter. Lord Tyrion’s levy on the city-states

came at the same time as Lady Magnolia's. So we answered his call while a smaller group was sent to Lady Reinhart. She will have an army, but it will be Lord Tyrion's that sweeps the Goblins away. Or so Father thinks."

"What? But that would mean you're supporting Lord Tyrion. While Aunt Magnolia..."

"It's just strategy, Yvlon. Lady Magnolia did not request for any [Lord] or any [Generals] to lead the army she's assembling, and she's no leader herself. Without a high-level commander, her army doesn't stand a chance. She could hold Invisil I suppose, but Lord Tyrion is one of our *best* war leaders. Moreover, he has his own personal army and is creating a vastly superior force to Lady Reinhart's."

That was true. Lord Tyrion was a famous [Lord]. And yet, he was at odds with Magnolia Reinhart, and she was one of the most powerful figures on Izril! If she wanted an army, she could raise one. Yvlon stared at Ylawes.

"But Magnolia is clearly trying to challenge the Goblin Lord. Otherwise, why would she assemble an army?"

"I don't know. For defense, perhaps. All of the forces she requested are assembling just west of Invisil by all accounts. I suspect that the officers of each unit will withdraw around Invisil to protect it if the Goblin Lord tries to take the city. They'll protect the citizens."

"And if Aunt Magnolia orders them to attack the Goblin Lord?"

Ylawes still didn't meet Yvlon's eyes. He traced on the table with a gauntleted finger.

"I...suspect they will politely refuse her request."

She stared at him, open-mouthed. Ylawes looked away.

“It’s not a lack of faith in her, Yvlon. It’s just...strategy. Magnolia Reinhart will have to be reasonable and see sense. She can’t ask the impossible. No one can.”

He said that, but Yvlon knew otherwise. The Reinharts—Magnolia in particular—were not known for being ‘reasonable’ about anything. They got their way. And if they didn’t, what did that say about the political situation in Izril? About the influence of the Reinharts, of Lady Magnolia?

It was all too big. Too far. Yvlon shook her head, putting distant conflicts with other nobles and the Goblin Lord out of her head. She looked at Ylawes.

“Be that as it may, I’m still not going north, brother. I’m staying here. I have a friend that might be in trouble and I won’t abandon my party.”

She folded her arms. Ylawes glared at her and blew out his cheeks slowly.

“I could drag you back—”

“No you couldn’t.”

“By all rights I should write to father and have him order you—”

“He can’t order me. This is a matter of honor, Ylawes. I belong with my group. I swore to fight with them. And besides—there’s a teammate of ours who might be alive. From the dungeon.”

“Truly?”

That threw Ylawes. Honor was important to him. It was to all of the Byres family. Yvlon explained about Calruz and saw his stubborn expression change. Ylawes wavered, rubbed at his eyes, and then came to a decision.

“You really won’t come back, will you? I was so sure...”

“No. I won’t.”

Yvlon felt triumphant as she looked at her brother. He was wavering, but he seemed to accept her decision at last. He looked at her with a rueful expression—and then dropped a house on her.

“In that case you won’t be alone. I’m staying too.”

He smiled at Yvlon, a [Knight] in shining armor. She stared at her brother, a famous Gold-rank adventurer, a hero, in horror.

“No. You really don’t have to.”

Ylawes faltered.

“Yvlon, I can’t just *leave* you—if mother heard, I’d be disowned within the hour. I have to stay and protect you!”

“I’d actually prefer it if you go.”

“Yv—”

“Stop calling me that. And I swear, if you think your team is going to babysit mine—”

Ah, family love. Across the inn, Erin polished her super-special and probably magical mithril coin with a cloth, watching Yvlon and Ylawes talk. They were clearly engaged in a serious debate. It was so nice to have a brother. Or so she assumed. She wondered what it was like.

And what the heck they were talking about.

Around midnight, Yvlon and Ylawes stopped arguing and rejoined the table. By this point, everyone who was awake was sitting around a table.

Ceria and Pisces, Falene and Dawil, Jelaqua—Ishkr, Drassi, and Lyonette had all been relieved and Erin was filling a few cups, but all was quiet.

Moore and Seborn had already gone to sleep, and Ksmvr had gone up to speak with Bird. About what was anyone's guess, but the air in the inn was generally convivial.

Generally. Sort of. Ceria and Pisces sat across the table from Falene, and Yvlon and Ylawes glared at each other like true siblings. Erin happily looked around and noticed Ilvriss slumped at his table, his mug cradled in one hand.

Decisions were being made. Ylawes didn't beat about the bush as he walked over to his two companions.

"We're staying, at least for now. We're challenging the dungeon in Liscor. Apparently there might be an adventurer stuck down there and Yvlon won't leave until he's found."

"I won't leave anyways."

Yvlon growled under her breath. Falene looked interested and Dawil pulled himself upright. The Dwarf's breath was practically toxic with alcohol fumes, but then, Jelaqua usually drank that much as well.

"What's this about an adventurer? Someone got themselves lost in the dungeon?"

"No."

Ylawes related the possibility of Calruz being alive as Ceria shot Yvlon a silent glance over the table. The armored woman gave Ceria a helpless shrug of her shoulders.

The silence that followed Ylawes' explanation was long. Erin looked around and recalled a similar scene the time Pisces had broken the news.

Okay, so there was a possibility, however faint, that Calruz could be alive. However, and this was a huge however, if he *was* alive he could be anywhere in a huge dungeon the size of a city. The odds were that he was dead, and the dungeon had killed everyone but the two Gold-rank teams who'd gone into it. And they had to be very cautious as well. Erin remembered days when Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers would come back looking beat up, talking about monster ambushes and traps.

“So this Silver-rank team that *might* be Gold-rank is planning on finding their missing buddy all on their own, are they? You're right Ylawes; that sounds exactly like the idiocy you'd get us tangled up in!”

Dawil groaned aloud and slapped his forehead. Ylawes glared at him and Ceria cleared her throat for everyone's attention.

“You don't have to help. We can't pay—not anything worth the risk—and there's no reward in it. This is our companion. We'll find him. If he's alive, he'll stay that way after so long. If not...we're working on it.”

They'd been taking requests to earn money for potions and so on, gathering experience. Pisces nodded as he played with his mug and Yvlon's face was set. The Silver Swords looked at each other as Jelaqua glanced at the ground. Erin knew the Selphid hadn't volunteered her team.

She couldn't fault Jelaqua on that. That was the sane decision. Which made the Silver Swords' one all the stranger. Ylawes looked at Falene, who raised her hand palm up, and then at Dawil, who muttered but nodded. He turned back to Ceria.

“We don't need payment or a reward, Miss Ceria. The cause itself is enough. Any friend of Yvlon's is a friend of ours. And if there is truly an adventurer in danger in Liscor's dungeon, we will do everything we can to help. We, the Silver Swords, champion causes wherever they may be found, regardless of reward or risk!”

He said the words simply, as if they were a fact. He stood proudly as he said them, and his armor glinted in the faint firelight. Everyone else stared at him with open mouths. Slowly, Ceria leaned over and whispered to Pisces very softly.

“Is he...real? Or just completely insane?”

Pisces sniffed.

“Addled from one too many hits to the head is more likely. Or perhaps he suffers from some kind of martyrdom complex. No doubt a sad affliction of the [Knight] class.”

He didn’t bother to lower his voice. Ylawes glared at Pisces.

“Helping others in need is simply common sense, sir. If you saw a traveler on the road who was in trouble, would you help them?”

Pisces frowned.

“Would this be a man or a woman? Human? Drake? How rich are their clothes? Is there any danger nearby? How far am I from civilization? What kind of road is it?”

Ylawes stared at Pisces. The [Necromancer] smirked at him and Ylawes looked away, disgusted. Erin clapped her hands, breaking the silence.

“Good! You’re staying. And you’re helping Yvlon! Yay. Now, are you staying *here*? I have rooms.”

The Silver Swords looked at each other. Ylawes looked uncomfortable as he bowed slightly to Erin.

“My apologies, Miss Erin. But I don’t feel at ease sleeping under the same roof as...Goblins. I would like to use your door to find lodgings in Celum.”

“Or you could go all the way back home.”

“Yv...”

“That’s okay. I think the Goblins don’t like you anyways. Sorry, but that’s how it is.”

“Ah—yes. I’m...glad that we can all feel comfortable.”

Ylawes stumbled over his words and turned back to the others as a whole.

“I must apologize for my conduct earlier. I was not aware of the... peculiarities of this inn. However, as Yvlon’s older brother I thank you most sincerely for aiding her. She is of House Byres, and a credit to her family. I hope that you will all continue to aid her in the future.”

Yvlon covered her face with her hands, blushing. Ceria and Pisces exchanged a glance. Jelaqua raised a mug.

“I’ll drink to whatever that was! House Byres, huh? I knew Yvlon came from a rich family, but I didn’t know she was nobility! Fancy that.”

“We’re not a famous House, actually, Jelaqua. Far from it. We’re minor and we don’t get political. *Until now.*”

Yvlon glared at Ylawes as she spoke. He nodded.

“House Byres has always supported itself with a healthy business in silver. We have a mine...and several of our family are [Merchants]. Some, like Yvlon and myself, follow the family tradition of taking up arms to defend the common people.”

“Wow! You’re like a real [Knight] family, huh?”

Erin looked approvingly at Yvlon. She scowled.

“In decline. Ylawes and my other sibling help provide for the family, but we’re not rich, Erin.”

“True.”

Ylawes frowned.

“In the past our family used to be richer. Alas, there’s less call for quality silver now, which is one of our main exports. In the past of course, we were a household name, but the disappearance of the Vampires has reduced our estates too—”

“Did you say *Vampires*?”

Erin was at Ylawes’ side so fast she could have teleported. The [Knight] blinked at her.

“Um, yes. Vampires. Indeed. They used to be a scourge on Izril and had several large infestations that were wiped out over the centuries. Our family, House Byres, was famous for rooting them out. And our silver was a key component of their destruction. It used to be said that if you wanted to survive a Vampire attack, you would wear a necklace of Byres silver.”

“Or garlic.”

Pisces muttered under his breath. Ylawes scowled at him. For once, Yvlon seemed to appreciate the [Mage]’s remarks. She shook her head as Erin looked disappointed.

“Vampires are gone, Erin. Or if they’re around, there’s not thousands of them like there were. My family’s well-enough off, even if *some* of us are more protective than they should be.”

She glared at Ylawes, and Falene smiled. She looked at Erin, one hand resting on her staff.

“That is House Byres for you, Miss Erin. They are rather infamous locally. Honorable, prolific, and stubborn as mules. I believe that’s what’s said behind their backs.”

Erin laughed as both Yvlon and Ylawes turned to glare at Falene. She smiled and looked around.

“Well, I guess I have more regulars in the inn, even if you’re not staying here. That’s cool. I’ll show you guys how to get through Celum and back—it’s really easy, but I have to make sure you don’t trip over any of Octavia’s stuff when you go through the first time. She’s an [Alchemist].”

She showed the Silver Swords how to get to Celum as the others went to their beds. It was late—so late that Octavia was asleep, which was lucky. A midnight sales pitch was the last thing Erin wanted. She went to sleep happy, but exhausted, in a silent inn.

[Magical Innkeeper Level 33!]

And then Erin sat up and remembered Ilvriss was still there.

“Darn it, I forgot I spiked his drink!”

She looked around her dark kitchen, wondering if she should wake the Drake up from whatever memory he was seeing. But then she decided it wasn’t worth the effort and went back to sleep.

“A brother coming to rescue her, huh? That’s nice. But I wonder what’s up with Lady Magnolia? And the Goblins? It sounds...not good.”

Erin’s eyes slowly closed. She went to sleep, dreaming of Goblins and silver and flying spaghetti monsters. Because it was a dream after all.

And in the inn, slumped over at his table, Ilvriss spoke one word.

“Periss?”

“Periss?”

He knew he was dreaming. Ilvriss could tell by the little clues. The windowless room, the way there was no real smell, no sense of beginning or end to this place, and the tiny Corusdeer leaping about the table in front of him. He stared at them for a few seconds before looking up.

There she was. Even if it was a dream, it was the only one he’d ever want to have. Periss, his second-in-command, his secret lover, stood across from him. She was standing over the table, which was, in fact, a map.

It was the most realistic map in the world. A little world, the map of Izril surrounded by the ocean, had been replicated in minute detail down to the very trees on the table. Animals too. Ilvriss could see herds of tiny Corusdeer bounding across the melting snowy landscape, and a miniature Hollowstone Deceiver, a Rock Crab, snagged one and tore it apart in a bloody mess as he watched.

The map was in fact a replica of one of the magical map rooms in the Walled City of Salazar. It was depicting the Goblin Lord’s forces as he moved steadily northwards towards Invrissil. It seemed remarkably accurate for a dream map.

Ilvriss didn’t care. He only had eyes for Periss. But she was studying the map intently, not looking up at him. She brushed a claw over the light blue scales near the spines on her head, a gesture so familiar that Ilvriss could have wept.

“Periss!”

“I heard you, Wall Lord, there’s no need to shout.”

Periss looked up with a slight frown. Ilvriss would have run over to her, but he couldn’t move. He was fixed in place on the other side of the map. He stared at her. She was so real! In this place, she was the only thing aside from the map that had any presence. And the dream had copied her down to the last detail. The faint odor of her body, the smell of her armor and the polish applied to it, the sounds her claws made as they faintly rasped against the map.

So real. It was pain, seeing her. Ilvriss would have strained to move, but in this dream, he couldn’t. He couldn’t *try*. It was a dream rule, and he was powerless. So he spread his arms.

“Periss. Come to me.”

“Not now.”

The Drake woman was focusing. She was tracing the path of the Goblin Lord, frowning. Ilvriss raised his voice.

“Periss! Come away from the map! I want to touch you. I want to hold you. It’s been so long—”

“It will have to be longer, Wall Lord. We have business here, or have you forgotten the Goblin Lord?”

“Damn the Goblin Lord. I don’t care about him or the Humans.”

Ilvriss spoke urgently. Periss looked up for a moment and smiled—his heart leapt in his chest.

“Neither do I. But they are potential threats. Just look here.”

She traced a claw along the Goblin Lord’s route. Ilvriss saw black smoke rising from a collection of burnt houses, fresh.

“He’s been destroying villages, one small town...but avoiding all of the cities, even the ones he could take. He’s conserving his forces, trying to move fast. Why? To avoid a Drake army coming from the rear? Or something else?”

“Periss...”

“And here. He’s going to hit Invrissil unless he turns. The Humans are assembling a force to stop him, but will it be enough? Magnolia Reinhart’s not known for her prowess in battle. Whereas Tyrion is assembling a force *here*, but it won’t be in time to save Invrissil. If the Goblin Lord attacks.”

It was agony seeing Periss standing over the map. Ilvriss tried to move again and failed. She went on, focused, gnawing at a lip as she did when she was thinking hard.

“It *could* all be open-and-shut if the Goblin Lord is defeated. But what if he’s not? I know there’s a small force coming to defend Liscor and another army coming north. If they’re needed, if the Goblin Lord isn’t stopped by the Humans, we’ll want to be ready.”

“Who cares? Let it all burn. Just come to me and I’ll leave it behind.”

Ilvriss would have damned his home to ash and fire just to reach out for her in that moment. Periss looked up and glared at him.

“Don’t say what you don’t mean. Look, it’s all predictable, unless the Reinhart woman has a trick up her sleeve. Her army might be able to fend off the Goblin Lord, but never destroy his army. Not without a leader. The key is what General Shiverail knows. Why did he disappear? Unless...no, he wouldn’t do that. Would he?”

It didn’t matter. None of it did. Periss was *here*, but she was ignoring him. Ilvriss collapsed onto the floor. He begged out loud, he who had never begged before.

“Please, Periss! Touch me. Come here. *Speak to me!*”

He shouted the last words, cursing the dream he was in, this nightmare, this cruel torture. There was only silence in reply. He wept, clutching the map table, feeling the ocean and land crumbling under his claws. And then he heard a voice.

“Oh, Ilvriss.”

Periss walked around the table. Disbelieving, Ilvriss looked up. She knelt, and then slapped him.

He gaped. Periss was no weakling. She was a trained warrior and her blow made his head ring. She hit him on the other cheek and Ilvriss reeled.

“Get ahold of yourself!”

She shouted at him. Ilvriss raised his hands to the real, stinging pain in his cheeks. Periss glared at him.

“I’m dead for less than a month and *this* is what you’re reduced to? You’re not the Drake I chose to follow, the leader I fell in love with! You drink and abandon your duties? Because of me?”

“Periss—”

“Stop saying my name like that.”

She glared at him and Ilvriss recalled that she didn’t like him saying her name, even in private. It was always [Lieutenant], then [Captain], and so on as she rose in rank. She disapproved of flirting before the battle was over, too. It was business while they were in the middle of a battle.

Suddenly, Ilvriss was conscious of how drunk he was, of how dirty his clothes were—clothes, not armor. He’d stopped putting it on. While Periss was in her armor, in the prime of her life, ready for action. He felt ashamed and looked away.

“Ancestors, look at me. Look at how I’ve fallen apart. No wonder you look at me like that. I am worthless.”

He sank downwards in misery. Of course she hated him. This was what he’d become. Instead of avenging her, he’d chased Ryoka this far, failed to stop Az’kerash’s minions from taking two lives, and then given up. The Necromancer. The grief had hit him too hard.

Now he had lost it all. Ilvriss couldn’t look at Periss. He heard her sigh in exasperation, and then felt a touch. He froze as she clumsily drew him towards her. Periss had never been one to hug, and so her embrace was crude, and uncomfortable as he pressed against her armor.

But it was real. Oh, so real.

“I know it was hard after I died. But you can’t keep doing this.”

“I tried.”

“I know. I know you did.”

“I fought, Periss. I tried, but—you are gone! Gone and I am alone.”

“I know. And I’m so sorry.”

She was here. In that moment, Ilvriss forgot decorum. He forgot his station and his appearance and began crying as if he were a hatchling. And Periss held him as she had never done, but as she would have if he had cried. Ilvriss clung to her, feeling her heartbeat. And he begged the world for this moment to continue, even in his grief. Another second. Another moment.

Please.

“You can’t waste away. *You* have a future and more importantly, a duty.”

The Lord of the Wall wept into her arms, clutching at her, feeling the *realness* of her body.

“I know! I know, but I can’t let you go. I can’t continue—”

“Of course you can. And you will.”

Periss gripped him on the arms, hard, looking into his eyes. Ilvriss grasped at her.

“I can’t just forget you and move on. I *cannot*, Periss. I—”

He couldn’t finish. The weight of moving without her, of waking from this dream and knowing she was gone was too heavy. Periss looked at Ilvriss and sighed, as if he was an idiot. He’d heard that sigh before, too. He’d used to hate it.

“You don’t have to forget me. I’d be insulted if you did. But you have to stand up. Your people need you. I need you.”

I need you. What choice did he have? Ilvriss stood, though the effort cost him more than words could say. He looked into Periss’ eyes, holding her. And in his heart he knew the dream was ending.

But not yet. Please, a moment longer. He had something he had to say. Ilvriss drew Periss closer and kissed her. She wasn’t good at that either. Neither was he, but it was genuine, real. And then he confessed his sins, the weight of his heart.

“I wanted to say sorry. To ask for forgiveness.”

She looked at him and laughed in his face.

“What forgiveness? For sending me after a lone Human girl? That was a sound decision. Although sending all those elites after me wasn’t. You should have kept the rest back so you could defeat Shivertail.”

Ilvriss blinked at her, surprised. But then he laughed too.

“You know what I mean!”

“Maybe I do, but the strategy was sound. And that’s what matters. You couldn’t have known. Now you need to move forwards. You know what the enemy looks like, where he is roughly. You know, and you can protect your people.”

Periss held Ilvriss, pointing towards the map. He looked and saw the undead rising around the Goblin Lord’s army. For the first time, hot fury flickered in his heart, drowning out the sorrow.

Then it faded. Ilvriss looked at Periss and held her tightly. She wasn’t fading or disappearing, but he sensed his time with her was ending.

“Don’t go. I have so much I want to do. So much I want to say.”

She raised one brow at him.

“As fun as it might be, I don’t think this is the right place for a tumble together. Maybe some other time.”

He laughed against his will.

“Will I ever see you again?”

She looked at him tenderly, and one of her claws intertwined with his.

“Maybe. If you have more of that strange drink Erin Solstice gave you, perhaps. But I’ll always be here.”

She pointed to the war map, the living continent of Izril, their home.

“Because that’s what you need to focus on. Not just the southern half. *All* of it, Ilvriss. And this inn in particular. There’s more for you to see, more to do. I can’t do anything anymore. But you can.”

Ilvriss closed his eyes. The weight of his duties fell upon his shoulders, but this time he could bear it. He had to. He spoke to her, feeling her claws in his.

“I swear I will. I will protect our home. I *will* find the Necromancer and make him pay. And if the Goblin Lord threatens, I will protect our people. I won’t slip back again, Periss. I swear it.”

“Good.”

He felt a kiss. When he opened his eyes, she was gone. But the memory remained. And as Ilvriss turned he opened his eyes—

And woke up. Ilvriss jerked upright at his table, and the nearly-empty mug of Faerie Flower ale tipped over. He grabbed for it and looked around.

It was pitch black in the inn. The fire was ash, and everyone had gone to sleep. Ilvriss stared at the mug, and then clenched his hand. He could *still* feel her, still hear her voice.

Had it been just a dream? The Human girl, Erin, had said—was it magic? A drug? Something more?

It didn’t matter. Ilvriss looked around the room. He was so tired. And then he looked into the mug. There were just dregs left.

Oh well. It would have to do. Ilvriss closed his eyes, and then sat up. He raised his mug and spoke into the silence. His voice echoed in the empty inn, coming back to him.

“To war. War, ever changing, always taking...to war. It’s the Drake way. And I—”

He drank and let the mug fall onto the table. The dream didn’t come back, but he hadn’t really expected it to. Ilvriss looked around, blinked, and then toppled off his seat. He slept on the floor, tears trickling from his eyes.

His heart was bitter, sore, and broken. But it was there, and it beat on, reminding him he was alive. Ilvriss slept and whispered her name as the map and colors and the promise of battle whirled in his dreams.

“Periss.”

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When she slept she forgot where she was and what had happened. It was only when she was awake that she remembered. Sleep was her one reprieve. But it was a coward's way out, so she woke up this morning as the sun hit her face. There was no running from the truth.

A young woman sat up in a tent, her body aching. She was alone. Far from home. For a few seconds, she looked around in the darkness. Then she inspected the restraints on her hands.

No good. They were as secure as they had been yesterday. The young woman thought about gnawing at the raw leather bindings, but gave up the idea. Her captors inspected the cords regularly.

There were no restraints on her legs, though. So the young woman stood up and walked around the tent. She could go to the bathroom so long as she didn't mind being watched. She could wander around the camp, and run about if she so chose. So long as she didn't cause trouble she was free.

That freedom would disappear if she tried to escape, though. And while the young woman knew she could run quite fast...no, it was still impossible. She was surrounded by the enemy. If she ran she'd be caught.

The same went for grabbing a weapon. She'd be overwhelmed in a second, and while the idea of going out in a blaze of violence was tempting, it was also wrong. She had to live. The young woman knew that. She had to live. It was her duty.

Still. In the confines of her dark tent, the young woman could tell it was just before dawn. She stretched as best she could with her bound hands, plotting another escape attempt. The guards around the camp were

numerous, but if she could get beyond the limits of the camp undetected, and have half an hour's, no, ten minutes' head start, she might outrun any pursuit.

“To hell with running. If I could *fly*—”

Osthia Blackwing grunted as she reached to touch her scaly feet with her arms. She twisted and tried to eye the black metal restraints that had been placed over the two leathery wings on her back. It was rather difficult; the young Drake woman couldn't see that far behind her. Normally she'd use a mirror to inspect her wings for injuries or flaking scales. However, she didn't have to look to *feel* the cold metal constricting the movement of her wings. She could move them, but she couldn't unfurl her wings.

It was agonizing. The Goblins who'd put the bindings on her probably hadn't any idea of how torturous that binding could be. In fact, they'd been extremely generous to her by the standards of prisoners; she could move about and eat whenever she wanted, she was left by herself unless the Goblin Lord wanted her, and she had her own tent. It was far better than how Drakes treated their captives, and Osthia might have been grateful were it not for her wings.

She longed to move them. It was like having her legs bound or—or having her eyelids forced open. All she wanted to do was flap her wings *once*. But of course, if she had that opportunity she'd be flying away in an instant.

And the Goblins weren't fools. If they afforded Osthia small freedoms, well, that was a peculiarity unique to her and only her. There were no other prisoners in the Goblin Lord's camp. None. They could treat one prisoner well. That she wasn't being raped or tortured didn't fool Osthia. She'd seen what the Goblins did to every other enemy soldier they'd captured.

After an hour of stretching and pacing around her tent restlessly, Osthia had to go out. It was that or go insane in the dark tent. She pushed through the dirty flaps of her tent, glancing around in disgust as she did.

The Goblin Lord's camp was already bustling as the first rays of daylight shone down on the continent of Izril. Osthia looked down rows of orderly tents, which slowly devolved into sleeping bags, and then just small campfires and cleared patches of dirt which Goblins slept around.

Despite the magnitude of the camp—meant to hold tens of thousands of Goblins each night—it was still organized. Central pathways led into the center of the camp and outwards, giving the streams of thousands of Goblins access to food, places to relieve themselves, social areas where they could squat, poke each other, and grunt in their foul language—

Osthia looked around, her face twisted into a scowl of disgust. She would rather be dead than a captive here. But she had no choice. As tempting as it might be to ambush a passing Goblin armed with a knife or sword, Osthia knew she couldn't die here. She had to survive.

Someone had to live to warn everyone. To tell them that the Goblin Lord was a pawn of Az'kerash, the Necromancer. At least one soldier had to return—few had seen the truth, or realized what it meant. Osthia had witnessed two entire Drake armies eradicated to the last soldier, only the stragglers on the outside escaping to tell of the Goblin Lord's incredible comeback. But she had been at her uncle's side. She had stood next to Thrissiam Blackwing and realized the truth.

The Necromancer had created the Goblin Lord. And he was sending his minion to wreak havoc across Izril. He had *made* the Goblin Lord, taught

him necromancy, given him orders. It was because of him that two Drake armies had died. Osthia's stomach tightened at the thought.

Thrissiam Blackwing. Garusa Weatherfur. Two heroes of the Drakes had perished in battle. How long had it been? Weeks? A month?

It felt like yesterday. Osthia could still remember her uncle, Thrissiam, ordering her off the field. She could still see him cutting down the other general, the Gnoll he had loved for a short few days, Garusa, and then falling to the horde of undead. She wondered if he had been torn apart. Sometimes she hoped that was the case.

The undead stood silently a good distance away from the Goblin Lord's camp every night. They were always there, no matter where the Goblins travelled. A silent group of tens of thousands of undead, motionless, swaying occasionally in the breeze. Their foul rot was usually too far away to smell, but occasionally a strong breeze would waft the scent of death towards Osthia.

She stood at the edge of camp, ignoring the Goblins passing by who stared at her and pointed, staring at the undead. It was one of her habits. She would stare at the undead, picking out each Drake zombie or ghoul that she could see. Each one she'd search for some clue as to their rank, their identity in life. She'd recognized comrades, officers...but never her uncle. She prayed she never would. Still, if she saw him—it was so tempting to bring him a final peace, even if it meant becoming one of those horrors herself.

No. Osthia looked away, fighting down the dark urges again. Duty. As a prisoner she had to cling to her duty. If not, what was the point? So many Drakes had died—she owed them her life. Even if it meant living in this camp another day.

Against her will, her stomach rumbled, reminding her of the requirements for survival. Osthia turned, smelling the Goblin cooking pots hard at work. And realized she had an audience.

A group of tiny Goblins had gathered around the Drake. They were Goblin children. Osthia had never seen a Goblin child before, but she'd learned that was because Goblins were only functionally children for about six months to a year. After that, they could fend for themselves.

Well, Goblin babies learned to walk after about two weeks. After that they shot up in height rapidly. The children who'd gathered around behind Osthia stared at her with keen interest. They were short, unevenly dressed—some were naked—and picked at their noses, leaned on each other, or scratched themselves as they watched her.

“Get lost you little monsters!”

Osthia snapped at them angrily and the Goblin children scattered. A few passing Goblins looked at her warily, but the Drake knew better than to back up her words with any kind of action. And unfortunately, the Goblin children knew it too. As she stomped towards one of the cooking stations they followed her in a mass.

It was a game. They'd gather up behind her, trying to sneak up on Osthia and edge closer and closer. If she didn't look at them they'd poke her in the leg and then flee. Osthia hated it. She scattered the Goblin children with sharp words as she stomped towards the cooking pots.

Of course, the children weren't as bad as the adults. The Goblins that were eating breakfast stopped to stare at Osthia. They had no compunctions about staring openly, and several of them nudged each other and pointed at Osthia. The Goblins never got tired of her. Osthia ignored them all and strode up to the front of the line.

“Food.”

She growled at the female Goblin ladling hot soup into bowls. The Goblin woman glared at Osthia and pointed. *Back of the line.* Osthia knew what she meant without having to interpret the Goblin's crackling language. She stomped into line and waited, grinding her teeth until she was handed a bowl. When the Goblin filled it, Osthia raised the bowl to her lips and sniffed suspiciously at the broth.

She knew the Goblins ate their own. And worse, that they ate Drakes and other species. If it hadn't been for the presence of the undead, Osthia would have refused to eat at all for fear of eating Drakes or Gnolls. However, she'd checked and the Goblins had yet to use the meat of people in their broths. Fortunately or unfortunately, their stores were fat from raiding villages and towns, and they had more than enough meat from cows, horses, sheep, and sometimes, Corusdeer.

Not that they generally kept that. Meat was a luxury and day-by-day the Goblins lived on thick, filling soups made of whatever vegetables, grains, and what they had on hand. They seasoned their soups with a tiny bit of whatever meat they had.

At least it was palatable. Osthia grunted as she sipped at her bowl. The Goblin children who'd followed her were now pestering the Goblin server for a second breakfast. Osthia smiled grimly as the Goblin woman chased off the youngsters by smacking them with her serving ladle. Then she finished her soup, gulping down the hot mix and tossing her bowl in a pile with the other empty bowls.

Immediately three children jumped at Osthia's bowl and fought over it. Because the Drake hadn't licked it clean like all the other Goblins. She refused to, but the other Goblins left their bowls so clean you could eat your dinner out of them, which usually resulted in them being reused at least twenty times before needing to be washed.

"Disgusting."

The Drake sneered at the children. It annoyed her that she couldn't apply that word to the soup. The Goblins might be savage monsters, but they had their own [Cooks] and [Stirrers] who could make the soup halfway tasty. The Drake would rather die than acknowledge that, though. She walked away from the mob of children now fighting for her bowl, ignoring her stomach that protested it wasn't entirely full yet.

Time to observe. Osthia had no real restrictions in the camp, and so she could wander about. She took advantage of that freedom every day to scout out the Goblin Lord's army as it moved from place to place. It was probably futile, but Osthia comforted herself in thinking that it might be useful if she managed to escape before the Goblin Lord's army was destroyed.

Firstly. Organization. The Drake paced through the camp, staring at the lines of tents that had been used to house supplies and bodies. They were all looted from *her* army's camps! The Goblins wasted nothing. Indeed, most of the Goblin warriors she passed by were carrying arms made out of Drake steel. Every time she saw a Drake insignia on a scavenged breastplate or helm, Osthia ground her teeth.

It would be so easy to call the Goblins simple thieves and dismiss everything they did, but Osthia was actually bothered by the efficiency of the Goblin Lord's camp. While his army moved at a snail's pace, the camp still had to be disassembled and rebuilt every night. And it was, with what was worryingly close to military organization.

The Goblin Lord's forces were a far cry from an undisciplined Goblin tribe. He had sentries, regular patrols, and latrines! He'd stolen all of these ideas from other races. But that was the Goblin Lord. Osthia knew him better now. He was a thief. He stole *everything*. And he was terrifying because of that.

A Goblin found her as Osthia was watching a Goblin quartermaster handing out weapons to waiting soldiers. They'd even set up a temporary

smithy, where a team of Goblins were crudely repairing holes and damaged armor! Others were coating new armor with a black resin, a sticky substance that gave the Goblin Lord's forces their distinct black armor.

"Color coordination. Who gave the Goblin Lord the idea to mark his troops with colors? The Necromancer? Ancestors, he's managed to figure out how to organize them into battalions with officers! Did the Necromancer teach him that too?"

"No. Goblin Lord took idea from Drakes."

Osthia whirled as a guttural voice spoke behind her. A Hobgoblin grinned at the Drake, a female Goblin wearing steel armor. She had no weapons at her sides, but Osthia recognized her at once. The Hobgoblin was short for a Hob, but her head was unnaturally large. And as she grinned at Osthia, the Drake saw two rows of *metal* teeth glinting at her.

Snapjaw. She was one of the Goblin Lord's top lieutenants. Her teeth were a product of her class—some kind of fusion of enamel and steel. She grinned at Osthia and pointed to the Goblin smithy proudly.

"Goblin Lord see. Drakes hammer metal. Bang bang. Goblin Lord watch. He copy. Now we have armor."

Her voice was rough, and her words heavily accented. But she could speak the common tongue. Osthia narrowed her eyes and her tail lashed the ground as she looked at Snapjaw.

"Stolen armor, you mean. You can't forge it yourself. All you can do is repair the armor you loot."

The Hobgoblin woman looked at Osthia blankly.

"True. Take armor off dead. Fastest. Not enough time to make armor out of rocks. You stop staring now."

“Why? Afraid I’ll bother the Goblins?”

“No. Goblin Lord wants. You come.”

Snapjaw pointed vaguely behind her. Osthia held her ground. She resented being ordered.

“And if I’m busy?”

“You don’t come and I bite.”

The Hob grinned at Osthia, her teeth glinting in the daylight. The Drake stared into her crimson eyes for a moment and then nodded grudgingly. Snapjaw looked vaguely disappointed, but led Osthia through the camp at a quick walk.

As they moved, Osthia looked around. The smithy was already packing up; the Goblins were preparing to disassemble the camp. It was another day of marching. She wished she knew where they were going; she had no landmarks to guide her in the Human lands, but she knew they were heading north. The Goblin Lord had marched past Liscor, past Esthelm, and away from every major city. North. Why?

She might get an answer today. Osthia squared her shoulders and her wings tensed against their metal bindings as Snapjaw walked towards the heart of the camp. It had been nearly a week since the Goblin Lord had summoned her last. She had to memorize everything. Every clue, everything he said—

It was all she could do.

The Goblin Lord's tent mocked her every time she saw it. It was the former command tent of Thrissiam Blackwing, and it served the same purpose it had when the Drake [General] had been alive. Only now Goblins stood around it, black-armored Hobgoblins who looked at Osthia with unfriendly glances. She returned the looks.

“Open up. Got Drake.”

Snapjaw swaggered up to the front, grinning her unsettling grin at one of the Hobs. He shifted and replied, again in the common tongue.

“Goblin Lord talking. Meeting.”

Osthia saw Snapjaw glance at her, and the Hob nodded. She walked into the tent and the Hob barred Osthia from following her. She stared at the Hob and the fat Goblin stared down at her. He had a halberd in his hands, clearly looted, but he looked like he could use it.

It bothered her how many Goblins had learned to speak in common. No, it bothered her how much they'd copied an actual army. They didn't salute and their military structure was haphazard, but Osthia could see Goblin soldiers training in ranks from where she stood. Goblins. Training. It chilled her to see.

Osthia was a [Captain], and she'd graduated from Pallass' military academy with high marks. She understood the threats each species represented, and Goblins were ranked low as a general threat. However, that came with a huge condition that their numbers were regularly kept low by destroying tribes. If they were allowed to grow in numbers, Goblins quickly became a threat on par with the Antinium or Humans. In the worst case of a Goblin King, they were ranked as a threat that could pose a danger to multiple *continents*.

One of the reasons Goblins weren't a threat when there wasn't a Goblin King was that they were disorganized. Only when Goblin Lords brought

them together in numbers would they actually be a danger to cities. If they actually became a proper army on top of that—

The voices coming from the Goblin Lord's tent grew louder. Osthia stepped back as the tent flaps opened and a huge, *gigantic* Hob emerged. He was seven feet tall and instead of fat, his body looked like a solid wall of muscle. This Goblin was another of the Goblin Lord's foremost commanders. As far as Osthia could tell, his name was Eater Of Spears. She eyed his massive jaws. Eater of Spears looked down at Osthia but said nothing. He walked past her without a second glance, striding into the camp.

She'd never heard him speak. Osthia stared after his back, her eyes narrowed into slits. She could...probably take him. Not with a sword or spear obviously, but if she spat acid—

At the thought, Osthia felt a trickle of the corrosive bile spilling into her mouth from the glands in her throat, ready to be sprayed out. That was the one thing the Goblins couldn't restrain, and the reason why the Hobs were looking at her so warily.

Actually, they could put a muzzle on her, but the Goblin Lord had forbidden it. He'd offered Osthia a trade. She could walk around mostly free save for her claws and bindings on her wings. If she *did* melt anyone with her acid breath attack, he'd cut out her tongue and all of her claws.

It was still tempting. Osthia looked over her shoulder and saw more of the Goblin Lord's lieutenants filing out. Snapjaw, two Goblin [Necromancers], the Goblin known as Eggsnatcher who rode a huge Shield Spider and commanded a horde of spiders himself, a Goblin with no face...

They were all former Chieftains, all Goblins who led thousands of their kin into battle. Osthia stared at each one, memorizing their faces. When the

Goblin Lord's army was slain she would hunt them down herself. They couldn't be allowed to live.

The Goblin lieutenants stared at Osthia as they passed. Some laughed at her, others watched her warily. However, none were *afraid* of her. They did not fear what she represented, the might of a Walled City, or the promise of vengeance. They drew strength from their ruler.

Yes, when Goblins were mere tribes they were easy to handle. But when a Goblin Lord emerged they became an army. And each Goblin Lord was dangerous. They were all the equivalents of high-level [Generals]. And this one...Osthia saw the Hob guards holding open the tent flap and gesturing at her. She took a deep breath and stepped into the tent.

The Goblin Lord was waiting for her. He stood over a table with a map on it, looking downwards and not at her. For a second, Osthia thought she was staring at someone else. Her uncle. Then the Goblin Lord looked up and she realized his robes were black and his eyes were midnight, with white pupils. She clenched her jaw and her tail thrashed as she walked into the tent.

"Blackwing."

The Goblin Lord greeted Osthia with interest, staring at her with his unnatural pupils, appraising her with a glance. He was looking at a map of northern Izril. Osthia recognized it. It had belonged to her uncle. She nearly lunged at the Goblin Lord right then, but held herself back.

"What do you want with me?"

"Everything."

He grinned at her. The Goblin Lord was neither heavy nor tall. He was the size of the average Human, not built like a warrior. And he wasn't. He

was a [Mage] and wore robes rather than steel. Osthia shifted, thinking she could break his neck if only she had a moment—

But he was a Hob. And his control over magic was immense. She had seen him resurrect hundreds of bodies at the same time, and create black bolts of magic that consumed the life of everything they touched. The Goblin Lord watched Osthia as she circled the table around him.

“Cannot kill. Cannot run. Is good you are not causing trouble. But if you are frustrated, attack me and not my people.”

She jumped as he stared at her. How had he—? She saw his eyes appraising her from head to tail and turned her head away, scowling.

It was a peculiarity of the Goblin Lord. He didn’t seem to need truth spells to tell when she was lying. And he was uncannily good at guessing her thoughts from her posture. Yes, that was his nature. He was a thief. The Goblin Lord had stolen all the ideas that made up his army, from the way he organized the camp and drilled his soldiers to the secrets of smithing. And if it was just that he wouldn’t be terrifying. But the Goblin Lord was a master among thieves in his own way. He stole just by *looking*.

“What do you want?”

Osthia repeated the question, staring around the tent. The Goblin Lord kept his personal tent mostly empty. He had no personal effects, none of the grisly trophies or magical tools she would have expected of a [Necromancer]. There was only a cot to sleep in, a trunk that might have held his belongings, scrolls, books on a table, the map, and, strangely, a vase with a flower sticking out of it. Osthia blinked.

It was just a wildflower, yellow with delicate petals. The Goblin Lord saw her looking and smiled.

“A gift.”

“Whose?”

“A child. He offered it to me when I healed his wounds with a potion. Gift for gift.”

The Goblin Lord smiled at the flower. Osthia stared at him blankly. The Goblin Lord shifted his black gaze to her and then his smile was a memory. He pointed at the map.

“We are approaching a city. A large one.”

“Does it have a name?”

“The Origin of Seeking Death.”

The Goblin Lord saw Osthia’s blank look and shook his head.

“That is Goblin name for it. It is called...Invril to others.”

He pointed at the map. Osthia blinked as she realized where they must be. *Invril*? They had travelled much further than she’d thought if they were approaching that city! But why would he attack there? It was one of the biggest Human cities, and sure to be defended. Unless he had a plan? The Goblin Lord watched her reaction carefully.

“The City of Adventurers. We know it. Many strong warriors live there. But adventurers. Not an army. Not a Drake city. Can it be taken?”

Osthia didn’t know. Invril was a city famous for its population of high-level adventurers, but it wasn’t fortified like Drake cities. It had an army and wealth, but if the Goblin Lord’s army swept in, could the adventurers make up for a lack of numbers? She didn’t want to answer either way.

Unfortunately, the Goblin Lord needed no answers. He grinned at her.

“You don’t know.”

“There are countless Gold-rank adventurers in the city. Sometimes Named Adventurers. If you want to try it while Human armies sweep in and attack you from every side—”

“You don’t know. But you fear I could do it. Which means there is a chance.”

Osthia bit her tongue and shut up. She tried to keep her tail as still as possible. It was always like this. The Goblin Lord spoke and she spoke—sometimes shouted—but he always seemed to come away with far more than she did. Now he turned back to the map and frowned at it.

“Strong city. Rich city. But not well-protected. Could take. But what if I said Humans were gathering an army?”

He glanced up and again Osthia went still.

“An army? How many soldiers are in the army? Who’s leading it?”

“Tens of thousands of soldiers. Forty? Sixty? Goblin scouts say many. Big army. Big as mine, without undead.”

Osthia looked away as the gears churned in her head. An army of that size should be superior to the Goblin Lord’s, especially if it fought defensively. Add in Gold-rank adventurers conscripted to defend the city... but without a [General], their army would be at a disadvantage—

She could refuse to speak, but she couldn’t turn off her mind. The Goblin Lord nodded as if Osthia had said it all out loud.

“Not good to attack. But army is too small to do anything but defend. Good appraisal. What my officers thought, too.”

He traced a curve around the city. Osthia glared daggers at him. The Goblin Lord stared at her, and then turned his head. He stared across his tent, towards the cot on his bed. There was a small scroll there. It was some

kind of specialized [Message] spell. Osthia had only seen him use it once. To contact Az'kerash. A shadow fell across the Goblin Lord's face and he looked at Osthia.

“Tell me more about him. The one who calls himself my master.”

So it had come to this. Osthia sighed. Every time the Goblin Lord summoned her he eventually asked the same question. And the problem was that Osthia had very little she could tell him. Granted, Az'kerash was the only topic she'd willingly advise the Goblin Lord on. But her knowledge on the Necromancer was...spotty at best.

“I've told you all I can remember. The Necromancer is famous. He lived on Terandria and was expelled from Wistram hundreds of years ago—”

“Yes. And is famous. But you know little of him. Famous is not important?”

The Goblin Lord interrupted, frowning at Osthia. She lashed her tail on the ground as she replied.

“Famous isn't important if you're *dead*. And we thought he was! I studied his actions of the Second Antinium Wars from a military perspective, not to understand how he thought!”

“So you know nothing more? Not why he attacked the Humans, not how he gained his powers? Not why he was expelled from this Wistram?”

When he put it like that, Osthia felt embarrassed. She tried to fold her arms, remembered she was manacled, and glared.

“No. He was—is—was—a Human. We don't memorize their histories. If you want to learn more, read a book. If you can read, that is.”

“A book?”

The Goblin Lord looked sharply at Osthia and she bit her tongue. But the Creler was out of the bag and it probably couldn't hurt. She nodded reluctantly.

"There is a book about him. Well, about the Antinium Wars, actually. It was written about both wars. The Necromancer is mentioned in the second war. If you want to read about him...go find a book."

"Hm. A book. What is it called?"

Osthia shrugged.

"*The History of the Antinium Wars*, I think. Sometimes it's in two parts, but most copies have both parts in them. If you want to learn about Az'kerash outside of finding some kind of Terandrian history book, that's your only option."

The Goblin Lord eyed Osthia for a few seconds and then nodded.

"Book. Good. I will see if it is found. I have several already."

He turned and pointed to the table in his tent. Osthia saw six books, all worn, sitting together. Her heart jumped painfully as she recognized one of the books. *The Triumph of Scales*. It was a classic military book. This particular copy had been Thrissiam's. She turned hostile eyes towards the Goblin Lord and then realized what he was implying.

"You can read?"

The Goblin standing over the tables shrugged as if it was natural. Which it wasn't. Not all *Drakes* knew how to read more than basic words and numbers—of course, literacy was universal in the largest Drake cities, but in villages and towns? How had he learned it?

"I knew how to read before the Necromancer found me. It is why he took interest in me."

“How? And why did he want you?”

It was a question the Goblin Lord refused to answer every time Osthia asked it. Again, he dodged it, peering at the map and smoothing a corner on the table.

“I taught myself. Before and after he trained me. He gave me spellbooks. Scrolls. I read more and more and learned from what I read. Now I read all I find. I would have more, but when my army loots cities, they forget books. Food is more important. And swords.”

He looked up at Osthia and tilted his head.

“What other books do you know of? Books on strategy? War?”

Osthia changed the subject quickly. She pointed at the map.

“Is the Necromancer ordering you to attack Invril? Is that why you summoned me here?”

He tilted his head at her and seemed to ponder the question. At last, he shook his head.

“No orders. Death, destruction, chaos. Not names. Not attacking Invril anyways. Going around. To this mountain.”

He pointed to the map. Osthia walked closer and saw he was pointing to a lone mountain northeast of Invril. It was a ways away, but clearly he’d have to pass by Invril to get there or take a long detour. Still...why that mountain? She stared at him.

“Is there something important in that mountain?”

“Yes. Goblins.”

He smiled at her surprise. The Goblin Lord walked around the table and Osthia backed up. He wasn’t afraid of her—he had a ring that could combat

her acid breath and he might be as strong as she was physically. Still, the proximity to him made her want to try and—she walked back as he spoke.

“I need more Goblins. More tribes. And there are more past Invisil. One is in mountains. The other...close by. I will have them join my army.”

“How do you know?”

The Goblin shrugged.

“I can sense them. Other Chieftains. Other Goblin Lords, too. Bright. In the distance like...lights.”

The Goblin Lord reached out, his claws touching for something invisible. Osthia shivered. Other Goblin Lords? Impossible! Unless they were hiding? Maybe in the deep jungles of Baleros—or Chandrar? It was possible they could be anywhere, in the mountains, in caves...Goblins lived in almost every climate. But Goblin *Lords*?

“Where are these other Goblin Lords?”

The Drake tried to keep her voice casual. The Goblin Lord stared into the distance and shook his head.

“Cannot tell. Too far. Only know two...three Chieftains close here. More distant. And many, many more further away. Across oceans...no Goblin Lords on this continent. Just I. And I am brightest.”

“Brightest? What, do you mean strongest?”

That would have reassured Osthia, but the Goblin Lord shook his head.

“No. Others are...dimmer. Do not call other Goblins loudly. May be strong, may not. But they do not say ‘come here’. Other Goblins cannot sense. But I? I *shout*. And all hear, although all do not obey.”

That made no sense to Osthia. Shining? Dimmer? It was probably a Goblin thing. But if he could sense the others, that confirmed at least one theory about their kind. She filed the information as well as the knowledge of other Goblin Lords away in her mind and stared at the Goblin Lord.

“If you think the Humans will just let you march around the city, you’re wrong.”

“Am I?”

The Goblin Lord looked at Osthia, tilting his head from side to side. She bit her tongue and he laughed.

“You don’t know. A Drake [Soldier] and you don’t know so much. That knowledge tells me much. What you know and don’t know. So. Come. We are moving. Around Invrisil. You come as we march.”

Around the tent, Osthia could hear Goblins shouting at each other and the sounds of activity. They were striking the camp. And today the Goblin Lord wanted Osthia following him around? As a trophy? Or unwilling advisor?

“What if I don’t want to go with you? Will you drag me around?”

The Goblin Lord was busy folding up the map, taking great care not to damage it. He looked up at Osthia, amused. He shook his head slowly, mocking her.

“You will come. To see. You watch me. You want to know what I do. You would not turn down this chance. You watch and I watch.”

He tapped one eye, grinning at Osthia with his white pupils. She shivered and opened her mouth to deny it. But she couldn’t. Instead she walked out of the tent. But not far. He was the enemy and Drakes did not run from the enemy. She would watch.

That was all she could do.

Within the hour, the Goblins had struck their camp. A huge, winding mass of Goblins marched north, flooding across forests, around lakes, over hills and grasslands, the youngest Goblins and those not suited to combat flanked by the Goblin Lord's main army. Other raiding groups of thousands of Goblins were already further afield, scouting or pillaging and sending riders back to the main host.

Goblins rarely rode, and apparently only a few tribes had learned to ride, much less domesticate animals. And when they did...Osthia saw the Goblin Lord riding on top of a massive Shield Spider, larger than a warhorse, slowly crawling at the head of the army. They were a peculiarity of his tribe, and many normal Goblins rode large Shield Spiders of their own.

They couldn't be used to pull wagons though, so the Goblin Lord's army had taken every horse, pony, mule, and donkey they could grab. The excess wagons and carts were pulled by groups of Hobs who churned across the ground with little effort in teams of six.

It wasn't a quiet march of course. Armies marching never were. Even the most disciplined of Drake armies seldom marched in silence; Osthia was used to hearing Drake war songs and loud jokes. Instead, she heard the Goblin equivalent. They chattered loudly at each other, screaming insults, laughing—sounds that were so normal, so *Drakeish* that they disturbed her.

In the background, she could hear war drums booming, sounding the Goblin Lord's advance across the landscape. They were meant to frighten and terrify, but the Goblins who heard the sounds appeared reassured. This

was their army, an army of their people, and it had brought them out of hiding. Where the Goblin Lord's drums sounded, there was safety.

And apparently, word of the Goblin Lord or his 'presence' was enough to attract more Goblins. As Osthia marched behind the Goblin Lord she saw small groups of Goblins appearing in the distance, streaming towards the army. Individual roamers, small gangs, and tribes would appear as the Goblin Lord marched, swelling his numbers. The Goblins were quickly assimilated into his army and usually without a hitch.

The one irregularity in the day's march came around midday as the Goblin Lord's army had paused for a meal. Osthia bit into some beans and porridge, watching the Goblin Lord feeding his Shield Spider parts of a horse that had died on the march. The huge spider snapped greedily at the meat and Osthia shuddered to see the Goblin Lord patting it on the head. Then she turned as she heard a commotion.

A Goblin had wandered up to the Goblin Lord's personal fire and was being roughly turned away by the Hobs who guarded him at all times. The Goblin Lord looked up and raised a hand and Osthia saw the intruder stumble forwards.

It was a Hob, but—one with a beard? Osthia stared as a Hob with a long and ragged grey beard stumbled forwards. She had never seen, never *heard* of a Goblin with facial hair. And this Hobgoblin looked old, for all he was still physically in shape. The Goblin Lord seemed equally surprised.

“Old.”

He walked towards the grey-beard Goblin and the old Hob fell to his knees, gabbling in the Goblin tongue. The Goblin Lord answered him, gesturing around the camp, and then tilted his head and asked a question. The Hob, looking relieved, replied, and then the two spoke in common to Osthia's surprise.

“How did you come here, old one? And how are you so old? How old? I have never seen Goblin with...”

Goblin Lord stroked at his chin and turned to Osthia. He pointed.

“What is the word?”

“Beard.”

Osthia replied after a moment’s hesitation. The Goblin Lord looked bemused. He repeated the word, tasting it.

“Beard. Beard. You are...Greybeard?”

“Yes, Goblin Lord! I am humble traveler. Once had tribe, but lost it! Too old, but too tough to die! Heard Goblin Lord’s call and came. Old Greybeard is so tired. Didn’t mean to intrude! Will go if unwanted. But asks Goblin Lord’s mercy!”

Greybeard practically flung himself at the Goblin Lord’s feet. The Goblin Lord looked amused as Osthia stared at the old pathetic Goblin in disgust. To her surprise, the Goblin Lord helped Greybeard up and invited him to sit and eat with him.

“Old one. You are welcome to my tribe. If you can fight, I will make you a soldier in my army. Otherwise, you will stay and help others. In camps, cooking, making arrows. You will have food and a place to sleep regardless.”

“Too kind! So kind! Is true, Goblin Lord protects. He calls and protects! With army! With swords and black armor! And undead!”

The Hob known as Greybeard eagerly grabbed the bowl of beans and began shoving them into his beard and mouth as if he were starved. Osthia edged back from him. The Goblin Lord had gone silent meanwhile. He

stared over to the army of undead that had marched silently alongside his own. Greybeard didn't appear to notice.

“So mighty! Crusher of Drakes! Has one prisoner! Mighty lord of undead! And slayer of Drakes! Take this one for torture? Ransom? Pleasure?”

He grinned lewdly at Osthia and she debated kicking him. The Goblin Lord frowned at Greybeard and shook his head.

“No, old one. That is not permitted. This one is for information. And undead are to protect. Will turn Humans, Drakes into undead.”

“And other Goblins?”

Greybeard looked up, a glint in his eyes as he stared at the Goblin Lord. Around him Osthia saw the eating Hobs look up and shift. The Goblin Lord glanced around and then looked at Greybeard and nodded.

“Yes. If must. Other Goblins. But only warriors. Only those who give permission.”

“Permission! To be undead after dead? Good joke!”

The old Goblin crackled with laughter, spraying bits of beans. The Goblin Lord frowned, looking vexed.

“Not joke. Undead are...tool. Sword. If they die instead of Goblins, good.”

“Hmm. Yes. Maybe. Goblins not like undead. But if make for Goblins to live, good? Better? Good question! Since Goblin Lord says, is right!”

It felt like Greybeard's obsequiousness wasn't earning him points among the other Goblins. Osthia looked around at scowling Hobs, but the Goblin Lord was patient.

“Old one. Anything is good to survive.”

“True. True! But how much? Bad question. Goblin Lord is Goblin Lord and that is good! But I hear things. As I come. Relieved that Goblin Lord protects!”

“Oh? What things?”

Osthia saw the Goblin Lord straighten. Greybeard glanced at him and again, she saw a glint in his eyes that belied his senility.

“Many things. Goblin Lord uses undead. Goblin Lord is not-Goblin. Foolish things by angry Goblins I think. But then I hear something else. I hear you are a slave.”

He grinned, crunching down on an uncooked bean. And then there *was* silence. Every Hob warrior sitting around the Goblin Lord looked up. The Goblin Lord froze, and Greybeard looked around, as if belatedly realizing he had said something wrong.

“Not slave? Goblins lie?”

Osthia held her breath as the old Goblin cocked his head, seemingly ignorant of the effect his words were having. The Goblin Lord stared at Greybeard. When he spoke, it was without a smile.

“Who said that?”

“Goblin only say—”

“Who said that?”

Greybeard flinched and dropped his bowl. He cowered as the Goblin Lord appeared bigger for a second and raised two hands protectively.

“Just hear! Just hear! Goblins say. Bad Goblins! Rumors of Necromancer, that all!”

Osthia stared at Greybeard as he hunched over. That was a good question. How *had* Greybeard heard that the Goblin Lord had a master, the Necromancer? Did other Goblins know? She would have pressed him further, but the old Goblin was close to—no, he was wetting himself with terror. The Goblin Lord relented as he edged backwards.

“Old one, calm. Not angry. If Goblins said slave, well—it is true. I have a master. One who teaches me magic.”

“Teaches? Teach Goblin? A master?”

Greybeard was open-mouthed. He suddenly brightened.

“Good, then! Master protects Goblins! Goblins are twice as safe with powerful master!”

The Goblin Lord laughed hollowly.

“Not, old Goblin. Master is death. Master of death. Casual death. Death of giants. You understand? He uses undead as tool, as sword. He uses me and Goblins as another sword.”

He pointed around the camp and Osthia saw the other Goblins looking down. Greybeard stared at the Goblin Lord.

“Not good master then. Slaves. If Goblin Lord is slave, are we all slaves? Are we all dying casual death, death of meaninglessness?”

“No.”

The Goblin Lord’s voice brought up the heads of the Goblins around him. He looked around and stood. The Goblins, Osthia, and Greybeard looked at him. The Goblin Lord nodded and tapped one of his eyes, so unlike the crimson eyes of regular Goblins.

“Am slave, old one. Am pupil with master. Am tool and sword. But not to die. A slave learns. A slave grows and lives. Necromancer gave me

strength. I created army.”

“But army is just tool. You said. Is being slave and sword good?”

Greybeard looked up slyly, and the Goblin Lord laughed. His laughter startled Greybeard and Osthia. He reached down and grinned at Greybeard.

“Better than being dead, old one. Slave will live. Slave may be sword, but sword will not break. And one day, Goblin Lord will not be slave. And until then, Goblin will do everything to survive. That is Goblin. Understand? Tell other Goblins that.”

He reached down and picked up the bowl of beans that had been overturned. The Goblin Lord offered it to the old Goblin. Greybeard picked at the beans, popping some into his mouth and ignoring the dirt. He smiled.

“Not tell other Goblins. They bad Goblins. Not like Goblin Lord. Slave is good, yes! Goblin Lord is wise.”

The Goblin Lord turned his head and glanced at Osthia. He smiled and she shivered.

“Not wise, old one. Learning. Learning is better than wise. Now come. Old one is wise and old. Will march with us and eat and sleep. Safety I promise.”

And that was that. To Osthia’s discontent she found herself marching alongside Greybeard. He smelled like fresh urine and dirt and he chattered constantly at her. She ignored him and marched after the Goblin Lord. She disliked admitting it, but the Goblins set a hard pace that a Drake army would have been impressed by. Even the children could keep up, though; it was actually the beasts of burden that tired before the Goblins.

They were passing along a large plains when a group of Goblins came riding hard towards the Goblin Lord’s army. They blew horns and waved their arms, and the Goblin Lord rode out to meet them. Osthia couldn’t

understand what they said until she caught up, but she recognized a patrol when she saw it.

“Army! Army!”

The patrol was ponies, a mule, and one horse ridden by regular Goblins. Only their leader was different. The Hobgoblin patrol leader was mounted on a horse, and his command of the common language was limited to say the least. The Goblin Lord nodded.

“Where?”

The patrol leader pointed over his shoulder and gabbled in Goblin. Then, apparently remembering, he switched back to the common language.

“Human city. Got army.”

“How many?”

The Goblins in the patrol conferred and the leader came back.

“Five thousand. Some horses. Many Humans on...feet.”

“Foot. Infantry.”

The Goblin Lord corrected his subordinates and grinned. He turned to the Goblins who’d all stopped to watch them and raised one hand. He pointed in the direction of the Human city, waved a hand, and raised two fingers, pointing at his lieutenants Snapjaw and Eater of Spears.

It was incomprehensible to Ostia, but somehow the Goblins understood at once. The main army began marching again, but a group of eight thousand Goblins broke off smoothly from the main mass. Ostia eyed the Goblins as the Goblin Lord himself rode forth.

“You don’t think you can take a Human army with similar numbers, do you?”

“Can. Must.”

He grinned at her as he pointed and the Goblins in his army roared and cheered. Osthia saw Snapjaw and Eater of Spears marching their units towards the Goblin Lord. She stared in disbelief.

Eight thousand Goblins versus five thousand Humans? It sounded like one of those trick questions back at the military academy. Unless all eight thousand Goblins were Hobs, she would expect them to be routed by any professional army. Even a Human one.

But the Goblin Lord thought he could win, and so his small detachment broke away from the main army. Osthia expected to be left behind, but to her surprise, she was marched in the Goblin Lord’s own private escort towards the Human city. More surprising was that Greybeard came with them.

“Can fight Goblin Lord! Have sword.”

He did indeed have a greatsword strapped to his back, rusted and battered though it was. Osthia personally doubted he could lift it, but the Goblin Lord seemed to have taken a liking to the old Goblin so they both marched in between a double wall of armored Hobs.

They were the Goblin Lord’s elite. He had thousands of Hobs, all of whom wore the best armor looted from other soldiers. They were strong, disciplined, and formed the core of his army. Added to his regular Goblins in their black armor and the Goblin Lord had a decent army. But Osthia would have still given the battle to any regular Drake army with a competent [General] if it wasn’t for the factor of undead.

They doubled the Goblin Lord’s army and could pull off maneuvers like digging themselves into the ground and ambushing the enemy, or sending out special exploding Goblin corpses to tear holes in an enemy’s line. With them, the Goblin Lord could overwhelm many armies with sheer bodies.

And yet, not one of the undead came with the Goblin Lord! It was a battle of eight thousand versus five thousand after all! Osthia didn't understand it. But the Goblin Lord was clearly bent on winning this battle without an advantage.

She hoped the Humans speared him through his arrogant face.

The Human army and their city came into view within twenty minutes. It was a rather large city that had grown up around a river. Their walls were short though, and the city had grown around the original keep. It was clear that the Humans wouldn't be able to withdraw behind the walls, so the army had come out to buy time for the people to evacuate.

They hadn't expected such a small force to attack them, though. Osthia's keen eyes spotted a sizable section of horsemen, but there were mainly infantry in the army. They didn't look like veterans, but to her surprise she saw a [Commander] leading the army. A Human on horseback wearing plate armor. He was rallying the army, marching them towards the Goblin Lord's forces.

"Commander. Lots of [Riders]."

Snapjaw commented to the Goblin Lord, licking her lips as she eyed the horses. The Goblin Lord nodded. He seemed eager for battle; he'd spread his Goblins out and was marching them in a large box-formation that Osthia was laughing at inside. It was a valid tactic, but it clearly showed the Goblin Lord's lack of experience. If Thrissiam or Garusa had been in command, they would be employing a far more dynamic formation designed to draw the Human cavalry in and annihilate them.

All the better, then. Osthia was on the Humans' side here. She hoped the Human [Commander] was high-level. The Goblin Lord might not be experienced, but his Skills could turn the tide if the Human was only Level 15 or something.

She got her answer as both armies closed with each other. The Goblins were cheering, ready for battle and clearly confident. Whereas the Humans had to know there was a massive force at least ten times their size marching past them. The Human [Commander] had halted them across the plains from the Goblins and was shouting at his men. Osthia could barely hear his voice, and then she heard him shout.

The Humans cheered, waving their weapons overhead, their voices reaching the Goblins as a faint roar. Osthia heard chuckles from the Hobs around the Goblin Lord. And then the Human [Commander] raised his voice and shouted.

“[Battle Roar]!”

There was sound, and then, as if someone had turned the volume up suddenly, the distant shouting became a *roar* that blasted over the Goblin Lord's army. Goblins cried out in surprise and alarm as the voices of the Humans became a crescendo of sound.

The howling that came from the Human army was far louder than it should have been. It was bestial, as if it came from a group ten times as large. It made the Goblins around Osthia hesitate and she found her heart beating rapidly as her mouth dried.

Fear swept through the Goblin ranks, making them hesitate. Osthia saw several Goblins and a few Hobs looking over their shoulders as if suddenly wishing they'd brought more of their friends. Strangely, Greybeard wasn't one of their number. He just poked a finger into his ear and scraped out some earwax.

The Human cheering was demoralizing the Goblins, sapping their energy to fight. But the Goblin Lord didn't waver. He stared at the other army as they screamed at him and then raised his arm. The Goblins around him looked up, and the Goblin Lord thrust his arm up and roared a word.

“Goblin!”

It was almost lost amid the tumultuous noise, but every soldier saw him shout it. They stared at their leader, the Goblin Lord, and Osthia saw their backs straighten, and the hesitation leave the Goblins around her. The Goblin Lord paused, looked around, and then thrust his arm up again. He shouted one word and this time every Goblin in his army joined in.

“Goblin!”

The word deafened Osthia and pushed back the howling chorus from the other army. She heard the voices of the Humans waver. The Goblin Lord thrust his arm up again and the Goblins around him howled.

He was trying to outdo the other army without a Skill! Osthia heard the Goblins around her howling and stamping the ground. The other army was shouting too—she could see the Human [Commander] raising his sword, shouting at them. But all she could hear was the Goblin Lord's army. They howled again.

“Goblin!”

The ground was shaking. Osthia saw the Human army waver, and then the Human [Commander] was shouting orders, riding forwards with a group of mounted warriors armed with lances. They were heading into battle. The Goblin Lord pointed and his army moved to meet them.

From her position in the center of the army, Osthia could see the battle unfold smoothly. She had given up looking for an opportunity to run; that would only come if the Goblin Lord's forces began to rout, and if that was the case she'd go for the Goblin Lord himself in that moment. Instead, she watched as an observer, free of the tension of fighting in the battle.

The cavalry charge of the Humans was one of their defining features that kept them on equal footing with the Drakes. Osthia had seen how their heavily-armored riders could smash into groups of infantry and rout them—their maneuverability was best on open fields like this. She had hopes they could charge through the Goblins' ranks despite the presence of Hobs. Until she saw the Goblin Lord's foremost ranks fall into line, Hob and Goblins alike forming a row of spears.

A spear wall! Osthia gasped aloud. That was a Drake formation, a standard of their armies! It was a proper formation too—the Goblins held position shoulder-to-shoulder, bracing themselves for the enemy charge. Behind them, more Goblins were readying themselves. The Humans would charge into the spear wall and as their momentum slowed, be hacked apart by Goblins in the next ranks.

It was a good plan. It might have worked too. The Human [Commander] led his men in a charge straight towards the Goblin lines, ignoring the arrows coming his way. Then at the last moment he raised his arm and jerked his mount sideways. The Goblins, braced for impact, stared as he and the thousand or so [Riders] turned.

The cavalry galloped *left*, narrowly avoiding the Goblins' front lines. And behind them, no longer concealed by the waves of horsemen, a line of archers and infantry appeared like magic. The archers began to loose volley after volley, catching the Goblins by surprise. The Goblin Lord blinked and Osthia exulted as a rain of deadly arrows streaked into the ranks of the

surprised Goblins, cutting them down as the horsemen circled and crashed into the left side of the Goblin Lord's forces.

“Hit them and away! Move!”

She could hear the Human [Commander] ordering his men, taking advantage of the chaos to strike the Goblins and then gallop away before they could be surrounded. It was a classic Human tactic. And meanwhile the Humans were outdistancing the Goblins with longer bows while their infantry advanced in a knot, clashing with the Goblins on the right side.

They were trying to crush the Goblins from two angles while they bombarded the Goblins' stationary lines from afar! Osthia saw a lone mage shooting a fireball into the Goblin ranks and for a second she dared hope. Then she saw the Goblin Lord raise his hand.

The [Mage] who'd cast the fireball spell was hidden behind a knot of infantry. The Goblin Lord aimed at the Human man and a streak of black energy formed around his fingers and shot towards the Humans. They tried to block it, but the black bolt went through their shields. The mage and eight soldiers in front of him fell forwards, dead in an instant. The Goblin Lord nodded, and then he pointed.

“Pull back! Goblins move here! Spears go here. And here! Move!”

He raised his voice as the Human cavalry charged again. The goblins shifted according to his orders and a line of spears raced to block the Humans. Rather than charge, they went around again, hitting another weak spot. The Goblin Lord narrowed his eyes.

“Snapjaw charges the right. Eater of Spears forward. Pull back those. Move archers behind Hobs there.”

The Goblin Lord pointed and spoke, and the Goblins around him shot into the army, shouting. Somehow each unit of Goblins heard the orders and

moved with incredible speed. Osthia gaped. She would never have expected any non-Drake army to react so fast, let alone a Goblin one! But they had an almost telepathic ability to read each other. The Goblins reformed, changing out of their box formation and into...Osthia saw the Human [Commander] waver and stare in disbelief.

The Goblins had changed their formations entirely. Battalions of archers stood behind lines of infantry, while a wedge of Hobgoblins and elites had broken off from the main army. It was a mirror of the Human army. For a second Osthia saw the Human leader waver, and then his face twisted in disgust under his helm. He pointed and his cavalry charged in as the Humans threw their infantry at the Goblin line.

Only this time the Goblin Lord was ready. He stared at the Human and nodded.

“Charging left. Move Hobs.”

Instantly, the line of Goblins shifted. The Human cavalry turned from their intended target and did indeed swerve left. Only this time rather than hitting an unprotected side they ran up against a wall of Hobs who were already ready with halberds, pikes, and spears. Worse, a group of Goblin archers was already loosing, aiming for the gaps in their horses’ armor.

The surprised cavalry pulled back as Goblins began peppering them with arrows. The Goblin Lord grinned and pointed.

“You charge! There and there!”

This time a group of Hobs took the offensive. Around eight hundred Goblins led by a core of Hobs charged straight towards a group of Human [Pikemen], only to swerve and hit the Humans in the side. Behind them, a second wave of Goblins charged forwards. A group of eight Goblin [Mages] began blasting the Humans with magic of their own.

“Impossible.”

Osthia stared at the Goblin Lord. He'd just copied the Human [Commander]! And as she watched, the Goblin Lord pulled back a group of infantry right as the Human formation charged into them. The Goblins melted backwards and fifteen Hobs stood up. They'd been hidden behind their smaller friends and now smashed into the surprised Humans from the front.

The Human [Commander] was at a loss. He charged again, this time hitting the Goblins hard, but they were ready, pulling back and letting him run into groups of Hobs and archers protected behind ranks of soldiers. And when the rest of his army tried to come to his aid, the wedge of Hobs circled around and hit them from the sides. They had to fall back and protect their exposed archers, while Goblins advanced from all sides, pulling off the same feinting maneuvers.

The enemy army was drawn into an unfolding trap of shifting Goblins as battalions would change positions, concealing each other's movements and surrounding the Humans in waves of oncoming Goblins. Osthia saw Humans fighting desperately, pressed in from all sides. She hoped their training would prove superior, but for all that the Humans were taller and stronger than the average Goblin, they were equally matched with the Goblin warriors.

And the Goblin Lord had brought his lieutenants and Hobs. He might have taken only a small force, but he had intended to crush his enemy all along. Now, hemmed in on all sides, the Humans came face-to-face with his officers.

Snapjaw raced into the ranks of Humans, her mouth gaping wide. She took a huge bite out of a Human, swallowing *half of his head*, helmet and all. She gulped, turned, and a Human stuck a sword tip into her mouth. Osthia expected the Goblin to fall, but Snapjaw just bit and then the Human

stumbled back, missing an arm. The Hobgoblin woman leapt on him as her soldiers pushed the rest of the Humans back.

In the center of the army, the Human cavalry had run into a wall of Hobs. They charged forwards fearlessly, intent on trampling the Hobs. The collisions between rider and Hob were terrible and left crippled horses and Hobs as one or the other broke from the impact. But the Humans had lances and if they could dodge the spears aiming at them or their mounts, they could take down a Hob in a single strike.

One [Rider] with a lance was charging Eater of Spears from the side. The Hob was finishing off a [Knight] on the ground. He turned too late and the rider charged the lance into his chest. Eater of Spears stumbled backwards and Osthia heard a *snap*.

The lance broke. The rider was thrown off his horse from the impact. Eater of Spears tore the lance out of his body with a roar and stomped on the [Rider]. Then he grabbed a potion, smashed the bottle into his side, and kept fighting.

Overwhelming. Overpowering. Without a superior strategy the humans lagged behind the Goblins at every turn. The Goblin Lord calmly blasted every [Mage] and high-level [Archer] he could find with his magic. Within ten minutes, the Humans were falling back, their army a fraction of what it was.

“Good strategy. Goblin Lord isn’t bad.”

From his position in the Goblin Lord’s escort, Greybeard looked approvingly across the battlefield. The Goblins had lost far fewer than the Humans. Osthia ground her teeth together, tail lashing the ground.

“It’s not over yet.”

And it wasn't. The Human [Commander] was pulling back, pointing at the Goblin Lord with a bloody sword. His cavalry had formed into a wedge, and the rest of his soldiers were massing up.

"They're trying to cut a path straight towards the Goblin Lord!"

It was their only choice if they wanted to strike any kind of blow. Osthia admired the Human [Commander] for his bravery. There was no way he'd survive, but taking that chance to strike a blow was a very Drakeish thing to do.

Of course, the Goblins could see what the Humans were doing. Eater of Spears and Snapjaw were both waiting in the middle of the ranks of the Goblins facing the Humans, ready to defend their leader with their lives. The Human raised a hand, ready to charge, when the Goblin Lord spoke.

"Clear a path."

Every head turned as the Goblin Lord pointed. The Goblins hesitated, but he repeated the order and his army slowly parted like the sea. The Humans stared in disbelief as the Goblin Lord ordered his Shield Spider mount forwards. He was looking straight at the Human [Commander].

"Ancestors, is he serious?"

Osthia breathed the words. The Goblin Lord couldn't really be taking the Human's gamble seriously, was he? But yes, the Goblin Lord had unsheathed his sword and was gesturing towards the Human in armor.

It was a duel. For a few seconds Osthia thought the [Commander] wouldn't take it, but then the Human spurred his mount and charged. His army roared as he charged towards the Goblin Lord. Around Osthia, the Goblins were shouting and screaming as the Goblin Lord ordered his Shield Spider forwards.

"He's insane!"

Osthia shouted the words out loud as the Goblin Lord charged towards the Human [Commander]. Was he an *idiot*? He was taking on a warrior—him, a [Mage]! Whatever the Human [Commander]’s level, he was clearly a warrior and what was more, he was armed for mounted combat.

He was charging towards the Goblin Lord, lance raised, surging behind his shield. Whereas the Goblin Lord only had a sword, a poor weapon for any kind of mounted combat. Osthia watched with bated breath. A [Lancer] could take down a far larger foe, even a Wyvern with a precise strike. The Goblin Lord was no [Warrior]—there was a chance!

“He could kill the Goblin Lord.”

“Hah! Hardly likely.”

Osthia turned. Greybeard was watching the duel. He looked amused as he looked at her.

“Think a Goblin Lord can be beaten so easily? Watch.”

The Drake turned back to the battle. And then she saw the Goblin Lord act. As his Shield Spider charged across the grass, the Goblin Lord raised his sword and spoke a word.

“[Arc of Midnight].”

His sword extended. The plain steel blade turned pitch-black and grew until it was a massive sword made out of darkness, as long as the Human [Commander]’s spear and three times as wide. It was a massive magical blade and Osthia saw the Human hesitate. But they came on.

Now the battle was up in the air. Osthia held her breath. The Human could still do it—he was rising in his saddle, trying to strike first! The Goblin Lord and the Human were fifty feet apart when the Goblin Lord raised his other empty hand and pointed casually towards the horse the Human was riding on.

“[Deathbolt].”

Black magic swirled around his finger and blasted out in the form of a long spear of darkness that sucked the light into it. The Human cried out and tried to swerve, but they were too close. The magic struck his horse.

The stallion stumbled and fell as the black bolt carved through it, turning the horse’s body grey and lifeless. The Human fell, cursing, and drew his sword. The Goblin Lord leaned down as the [Commander] stood. He swung the shimmering blade of magic as the Human charged at him.

There was silence as the Goblin Lord’s Shield Spider raced past the downed horse. Osthia saw the Human [Commander] falling—in two halves. The Goblin Lord raised his midnight blade, the arc of black magic shimmering in the air and sucking in light. He shouted and the Goblins around him howled in victory.

“That bastard. That cheating—”

Osthia stared at the Goblin Lord through tears as the Human army shouted their despair and fury. Some charged at the Goblin Lord and others loosed arrows, but the rest were retreating as the Goblin Lord’s army surged forwards. Without a leader, it was a massacre as Goblins cut down the fleeing Humans one by one.

“Cheating? He offered a duel and the Human took it. Not his fault if he thought a [Mage] would joust. More idiot, he.”

Greybeard leaned on his sword, watching the Goblin Lord leading his soldiers forwards. He was being shot at, but the arrows swerved before they could reach him. His ring of protection might have saved him from the lance thrust if he’d taken it. Osthia stared at Greybeard with pure hatred.

“You think he’s a hero, don’t you? That monster—you called him a slave, but you Goblins follow him even if he turns all of you into undead.”

“Not all. Only soldiers. Only those who ask. It makes a difference. And if he uses undead, so what? Velan hated undead. But our King is dead and a Goblin Lord is a Goblin Lord. He protects. The undead don’t matter.”

Greybeard turned his head to look at Osthia. She blinked.

“Why are you speaking—Velan? Velan the Kind? How do you know what he hated?”

The old Goblin grinned at her. They were alone now, the Hobs having left to guard their leader. Greybeard nodded towards the battle as the Goblins began looting the dead.

“Slave. A Goblin Lord who is slave to a Necromancer. That is new. I have known weaker Goblin Lords, but I have never met one who was a slave. But he *is* a Goblin Lord, however small.”

Something was off about Greybeard. He wasn’t acting like before. And his eyes—Osthia eyed the old Goblin. He was musing aloud, watching the Goblin Lord with narrowed eyes and stroking his beard.

“A coward, a child, and a slave. Interesting. And each one claims to be true Goblin?”

He laughed at that. Osthia stared at him.

“What are you talking about? A coward and a child? Do you mean other Goblin Lords? Or...other Goblin Chieftains?”

“Mm. Yes. All would be Goblin Lords of a kind. But which one would be best? A question for you, captive Drake.”

He grinned at her. Osthia glared.

“It sounds like any one of them would be a disgrace. If that’s the standard for a Goblin Lord, I pity your race.”

Greybeard raised his eyebrows, not drawn in by her insult.

“You don’t understand. That’s not the problem. A child? So what? A coward? So what? A slave?”

He paused.

“They are Goblin. Any of them might be worthy. One stands out more, though. Redfang. But he is not a true Goblin.”

Garen Redfang? Osthia had heard of him, seen his name on bounty posters. His tribe was dangerous, more than a match for one or two Gold-rank teams. His was the kind of tribe that would take an army to root out. Why had Greybeard mentioned him? Was he mixed up in all of this?

“What does Garen Redfang have to do with the Goblin Lord? Is he working with him?”

The old Goblin laughed at Osthia.

“Garen? Work with a Goblin Lord? He might *become* a Goblin Lord. And then there would be two. Or one if they clash. But that won’t happen.”

“Why not?”

Greybeard’s eyes glittered.

“He slaughtered his tribe. Adventurers. Other species. It matters not. He called them tribe and cut them down for a relic of our King. For hope. But he still cut them down. And so long as that is true, no matter how many false tribes he builds, no matter how strong his sword, he will never be a true Chieftain, much less a Lord. But if he changes...yes. Time to see him. This Goblin Lord will do anyways, if the others fail.”

He nodded at the Goblin Lord, and Osthia stared at Greybeard. He was like no other Goblin she’d met. Not even the Goblin Lord. He wore a mask, and it had come off. A Goblin with a beard. A Goblin who hid his identity.

“Who *are* you?”

Greybeard grinned at her.

“Just old! Don’t you mind. Tell Goblin Lord I liked his beans. Going now. Keep secret or I cut off tail. Drakes *hate* that.”

He turned. Osthia spat acid. Greybeard’s form *blurred* and he vanished. She saw him dash away from the spray of acid she’d shot at him and race across the plains. Only his laughter remained. She thought about running after him. But the Goblins were headed back her way and now the Goblin Lord was riding towards her as his Shield Spider chewed on a bloody body.

The Goblin Lord dismounted, still on a battle-high after his victory. Osthia stared blankly at his spider and their blood splattered armor and fresh acquisitions. Behind them, she could see hundreds, thousands of zombies and a few ghouls rising. More warriors. The Goblin Lord’s army grew.

“Where is the old one?”

The Goblin Lord stared at Osthia and looked around with a frown. She replied numbly.

“He left.”

“Where?”

“Don’t know. He wasn’t who he seemed to be.”

“I know.”

The young Drake woman stared at the Goblin Lord. He shrugged.

“Old Goblin with beard? Very suspicious. Knew too much. Wonder if I’ll see again. Doesn’t matter.”

“Why not?”

“He is Goblin and I am Goblin. We are all Goblin.”

The Goblin Lord was calm as he explained. They were of the same species, so they were on the same side. Osthia stared at him, uncomprehending. That wasn't how Drakes looked at each other.

Instead of replying, she looked around. The Goblin Lord's army had destroyed another Human army. Another one. And they were sending soldiers to pillage the city for supplies. At least the rest of the Humans had escaped. And that all begged the question: why?

“What is your goal? Why are you going north? Just for a few Goblin tribes? Or do you want something else?”

Osthia stared challengingly up at the Goblin Lord, ignoring Snapjaw's glare and the way Eater of Spears looked at her. The Goblin Lord shifted on his throne of chitin, patting his Shield Spider on the head. He smiled at her.

“To survive of course. It is easy. I win three battles and my people live.”

“What? Three battles?”

He nodded calmly and cast his eyes north. The Goblin Lord sat straight as he spoke, the other Goblins hearing his words and passing them on to the others.

“Goblins need a home. Goblins cannot be separate. We are too weak. We are *hunted*. So I will build one. I will win three battles. One against the Goblins who rebel. Another against the Humans. And a third, defending our home. I will build it in the mountains. And when all three battles are won, Goblins will know peace.”

“Impossible. The Drake high command would never—”

“Drakes? Drakes don't go north! Drakes don't trust Humans and Humans don't like Drakes. If I find a place for my people, one side will

send armies and the other one will squabble and do *nothing*. We will be a thorn for one and good for the other. You know that.”

The Goblin Lord pointed at her. Osthia opened her mouth and stopped. If he settled and made a Goblin city? She could imagine the Walled Cities sending an army north, but surely the Humans wouldn’t think of that as a declaration of war, right? But the last time a Drake army had gone north...

The Goblin Lord raised his voice, addressing his army.

“Three victories. One against Goblins. Then my army is strong. The second against Humans to show them we cannot be defeated. The last to defend a home, to show them that we are here to stay. It is possible! I have an army. I have a people. I have everything you Drakes have, what Humans have. If I am strong, my people will live. And I am strong!”

He raised his arms and his soldiers cheered. Osthia looked around. The Goblins in black armor shouted and cheered in their own language, shouting for the Goblin Lord. For a home.

She was alone among them. And as the Goblin Lord dismounted, as he pointed and his Goblins began to march back to their army, he looked at her. His white pupils surrounded by blackness were too knowing, too intelligent.

“This was good training.”

“Training?”

Osthia Blackwing looked back at the bloody battlefield, at the dead Humans and the undead shambling after the Goblin Lord’s army. She stared at the Goblin Lord, all her fury replaced by...

“Is that what you call it? What you call this? Training?”

“Hmm. Wrong word? Learning, then. I learn. How to hide troops, how to send them here and here. Your Drake [General] and Gnoll [General] taught me how to lead an army. Now I learn how to fight best with one. Learning, always learning. That is what makes me strong.”

He grinned at her. Osthia swallowed hard.

“The Necromancer made you strong. Without him you’re just...”

The Goblin Lord’s eyes flashed and she fell silent. He shook his head slowly.

“Necromancer made me stronger. But I was always strong. Goblins are weak. But we grow. We learn. And we take. From you. From Drakes, from Humans, from everyone. We take and take. And someday we won’t need to take any more. Someday we will be like you. And we will have a home.”

He stared at her and Osthia felt it. Creeping into her heart, like poison. She could deny it, pretend it wasn’t true, but it was. The Goblin Lord was more than a threat. More than a menace. She was afraid of him. And that promise in his eyes. The word he kept repeating.

“Home.”

Goblins had no homes. They were monsters. Savages. Tribal nuisances that had to be put down. Or they had been. Now, the ones in this army were something else. Osthia Blackwing looked into the Goblin Lord’s eyes and he smiled.

“Soon.”

4.47

[Lieutenant] Gershal of Vaunt was an unhappy man. He was not an important man, which factored into his present unhappiness. He was a low-level officer from a small city north of Invrissil. He commanded a group of disciplined but fairly low-level [Archers] and [Swordsmen], and he liked to think of himself as a decent soldier, albeit one who hadn't fought in any wars.

He and his men fought monsters, patrolled, kept the peace, and occasionally went to aid other cities, usually in suppressing a Goblin tribe or dealing with a monster infestation. They had never been levied for one of the annual battles against the Drakes, and Gershal hoped they never would be. When he'd heard about the Goblin Lord he'd been concerned for the other cities of course, but he'd assumed the Goblin threat would be taken care of long before they got close to his city.

What he'd never expected was to be *part* of the solution. When the levy request had come from Lady Magnolia Reinhart to Vaunt, the city [Mayor] had panicked. When another request came hours later from Lord Tyrion Veltras, Gershal had known there would be trouble. When two important nobles wanted the same thing, appeasing one and not the other could have terrible consequences, and yet, both requests had demanded a large force be sent, making appeasing both an impossibility.

Vaunt had made the logical choice. They'd sent four hundred [Soldiers] to Lord Tyrion Veltras, who, after all, was known as a battle-ready [Lord] and who would probably return most of the soldiers in one piece. They'd sent Gershal with two hundred of his men to Lady Magnolia.

The sacrificial lamb. Gershal strode about the camp he'd been assigned to, nervously tightening his sword belt and eyeing the other soldiers and officers milling about. Lines of orderly tents ran in every direction, each one inhabited by an officer from a different Human city.

"Dead gods, what a hodgepodge collection of units this is. Lady Reinhart wants to stop the Goblin Lord with *this*?"

Gershal grouched to himself as he walked past a group of officers dicing and drinking wine together. His throat cried out for a taste, but the [Lieutenant] moved past them. Drinking on duty? That wasn't a custom in *his* army.

And that was the thing. Magnolia's requests had drawn in so many disparate groups of soldiers from across the continent. Gershal was amazed their arrival to the camp just outside of Invril had been a disaster with them all arriving at once. Somehow he'd found there was a space ready for his soldiers to camp and a personal tent. That was something at least. But now he was waiting for orders and impatient with it. So Gershal walked through the camp, looking for anyone he might recognize.

As luck had it, he was recognized first.

"Gershal!"

A woman's voice made Gershal turn. He saw a woman in armor striding up to him. She raised a fist and Gershal, knowing what was coming, winced as he put up his own.

The sound of two gauntleted fists colliding made several officers look up. Gershal shook out his stinging knuckles and looked at the other officer who'd given him her city's unique greeting.

"Lieutenant Salvia. I should have known you'd be assigned here. Who did you offend to get this duty?"

“It’s [Captain] Salvia, you dour oaf! I specifically requested to come here—might as well be first to fight the Goblin Lord, eh? How’s Vaunt? Still making cheeses all year? How many soldiers did you send? Two hundred? Three?”

“Two. Half [Archers] and half [Swordsmen].”

“What, you mean those Level 5 [Farmers] who’ve barely trained with a bow more than a month? Poor show!”

“Better than a bunch of [Riders] who spend all their time looking after a bunch of flea-ridden nags all day.”

Gershal and Salvia stared at each other for a second, and then she laughed and clapped him on the shoulder.

“You don’t change, do you? Come on, let’s have a drink!”

“I shouldn’t. We *are* on duty...”

“Don’t be like that! There’s no commander about and unless Magnolia Reinhart graces us with her presence in person, we’ve nothing to do but talk. I have a bottle of wine in my tent. Let’s take it out and drink something. Pshaw! This weather’s not warming fast enough for my taste!”

In short order, Gershal found himself sitting with Salvia at a table, drinking cheap wine from equally cheap tin cups. It wasn’t what Gershal would have preferred, but he was too polite to say otherwise.

Besides, he knew Salvia. Her city, Nonelmar, was close to his and they’d gotten to know each other over the years. Nonelmar was more prosperous owing to its richer soil which provided it with grazing pastures and bountiful fields alike, but Vaunt could pride itself on producing some of the best cheeses on the continent. In fact, Gershal had some of his city’s famous cheese with him and soon he and Salvia were sharing slices of the

spicy cheese known as Peppermort, exceptionally fragrant and long-lasting. It also went well with wine, even cheap wine.

“Good stuff! I can’t tell you how much I miss your city’s cheeses. I tried to buy some in Invrisil as soon as my soldiers settled in, but you wouldn’t believe the prices!”

“They are high right before spring. You’re lucky you met me—I hear some of our cheeses are going for eight silver pieces per pound at the moment.”

Salvia swore and Gershal smiled, although he was slightly jealous. He hadn’t even contemplated a trip into Invrisil, for all it was a few miles away from the officer’s camp. Vaunt couldn’t afford to pay its [Lieutenants] that much, and a [Captain]’s salary allowed for far more luxuries.

Rather than ask how Salvia had gotten her promotion, which wouldn’t be polite, Gershal looked around the camp.

“You say your soldiers got here yesterday? We only arrived this morning. Do you think we’ll be waiting long to see what Lady Reinhart does with us?”

Salvia bit into a slice of cheese and sipped some wine, shrugging.

“Can’t say. Your group is one of the last to arrive or so it seems. We’re nearly full in the camps, and the soldiers are restless. Could be we’ll just sit here until the Goblin Lord arrives and if he attacks, we’ll do our bits. Otherwise...”

Gershal frowned, worried. He leaned forwards over the low wooden table towards Salvia.

“She won’t order us into battle, would she? Lady Reinhart has to know that a force like this won’t stand up to a regular army—even a Goblin Lord’s. Without a commander of some sort...”

“She might have one. Invisil has a few [Strategists] and it’s not like she couldn’t send for a [Commander] from one of the larger cities.”

“Be reasonable Salvia. A local [Commander] is no match for a Goblin Lord. If it comes to a battle, I could see our groups holding the line in the city with adventurers. But an offensive is suicide! Lord Tyrion is gathering an army of his own, and it’s going to be twice as large as this one. Let him take care of the Goblin Lord. Not Lady Reinhart, who is, with all respect, *not* a general.”

Gershal looked around as he said this. It wasn’t wise to badmouth Lady Magnolia, but he had to state his opinions, which were close to fact in this case. Salvia made a face.

“I know. I know. I have orders not to participate in any assaults on the Goblin Lord unless I’m sure I can pull my boys out safely. And I’ll bet half the officers here won’t commit to an assault either. You’re not alone Gershal—just don’t say it anywhere Lady Reinhart’s people might hear.”

“They’re not here, are they?”

The [Lieutenant] looked around, worried. Salvia shook her head and pointed to a pair of [Knights] in pinkish-red armor who were striding through the camp.

“Not her people exactly, but see those two? They’re [Knights] in service to Lady Bethal.”

“Oh.”

Gershal knew that Lady Bethal Walchaís and her house were strongly aligned with the Reinhart family. Still, the two [Knights] did little to strike fear into his heart.

“Aren’t those the Knights of the Flower or something? I’ve heard about them. Arrogant hotheads or so I’ve been led to believe. All the more reason

why this army lacks cohesion. If I have to fight with those eyesores—”

Salvia kicked Gershal under the table, making him wince and clutch at his leg. She glared at him, tin cup held tensely in her hand.

“Don’t say that within earshot, you fool! The Knights of the Petal take any insult against their [Lady] or their order to heart. They’ve thrashed officers who’ve laughed at them and they’ll break bones if you insult Lady Bethal.”

Gershal shut up. Salvia put down her cup and reached for the wine bottle to refill it.

“They might dress like pink flowers, but they’re the real deal on the battlefield, Gershal. I hear their armor is all custom-made Dwarf work, enchanted by Wistram mages. They’re nigh-invincible against mundane arms and they all have magical weapons. If there’s any group I’d want to be charging into the Goblin Lord’s ranks, it’s them.”

“Oh.”

Instantly Gershal reevaluated his opinion of the two Rose Knights. Dwarf-made armor? His armor was iron, and not exactly top-rate iron at that. He’d be grateful for some high-quality steel, let alone a piece of armor from the Dwarf forges of Terandria. Yet the presence of Lady Bethal’s knights still didn’t assuage his concerns.

“That’s one elite group. But I don’t see any other notable force. By all accounts Lord Veltras has gathered a far larger army—he called for six *thousand* horse from the Terland family and they sent it! At least a quarter were [Knights], whereas I can count the number of crests here in the hundreds.”

“Yes, yes. I get what you’re saying Gershal. But we were called here to protect Invril from the Goblin Lord.”

“I have no problems with that. But doing it alone—”

Gershal broke off, knowing he was belaboring the point. His heart ached for the villages and towns that had already been destroyed by the Goblin Lord. But he was, if nothing else, a pragmatist. Without a true leader—or twice as many soldiers—he feared that any attempt to do battle with the Goblin Lord would only level up his Goblins and create more undead.

He was worried and unhappy, and unfortunately, the alcohol only made his mood worse. Gershal and Salvia had finished half the bottle and were sharing his cheese and her wine with some other officers they’d met when they heard a horn blowing to the east of camp. Everyone looked up.

“That’s odd. They haven’t announced anyone since Lady Bethal and her escort rode in.”

“Might be a small [Lord] leading his soldiers personally. Poor fellow if he is—I doubt he’ll see much battle on defensive duty.”

“Hang on—listen. There are more horns. This is no local lord.”

Indeed, more horns were blowing, heralding the arrival of someone important. Gershal rose to his feet and saw a man on horseback riding through the camp.

“All officers! Assemble at the center of camp! Lady Magnolia Reinhart has arrived in person! She will be discussing the coming battle against the Goblin Lord!”

“Oh, dead gods.”

Salvia paled and Gershal felt his heart jump in his chest. Coming battle? He looked around at the other officers. They were all looking uneasy.

“We’ll—just have to see what she says. Perhaps she intends to hold the city.”

“No problems there. But he said ‘coming battle’. If she wants us to attack...”

“We’ll just have to tell her it’s not feasible. There’s a few [Captains] and some [Lords] among us—they can say it to her face.”

“Not I.”

Salvia looked pale at the idea, and the officer who’d suggested it paused.

“Well, we’ll just have to say it together. She can’t object to all of us stating the truth.”

Silence followed his words. Gershal stopped himself from pointing out that Lady Magnolia Reinhart could do what she very well pleased. If she grew angry at all of the officers present...he sighed.

“We’d better see what she wants.”

“True.”

The officers began moving in a mass towards the center of the camp, where a wooden stage had been placed. Gershal had wondered what it was for—now he realized it was for the Lady Reinhart. He prayed she wouldn’t make the wrong decision.

“Someone has to destroy the Goblin Lord.”

Salvia muttered to Gershal as they walked. Gershal nodded. He’d wrapped his cheese carefully in wax paper and was tucking it into his armor. Cheese. It was a local superstition among his city. A cheese had once stopped an arrow that had gone through a [Soldier]’s armor. Now all of the young men and women who left Vaunt carried cheese when they went into battle. It was a good field ration and it reminded them of home.

He wondered what the traditions of the villages and cities around Invrisil were like. Gershal felt a pang as he imagined the Goblin Lord's army laying waste to them. Someone had to stop the Goblin Lord, indeed. But—

Not this army. Not them. They were too small. Gershal closed his eyes. And then he heard a susurrations, saw the ranks of men and women parting, and knew Lady Magnolia Reinhart was approaching. He had never met her before in his life, but Gershal knew the rumors surrounding her. She was cunning, deadly, manipulative, and, it was said, cold-hearted as the snow itself. But she had never been called a fool.

He hoped that today wouldn't prove the rumors wrong.

"Lady Reinhart? General Shivertail? We have arrived."

Reynold's voice came from the front of the carriage, slightly muffled. He guided the pink magical carriage to a stop as the camp full of officers came into view. It was the smaller camp to the sprawling campgrounds next to it, where the soldiers from each unit were waiting.

The ground was cleared, and the melted snow had revealed wet but sturdy earth. The growing plant life had been trampled by thousands of boots. Now it was muddy, and Ressa wrinkled her nose as she stepped out into the mud.

"You shouldn't have brought a dress."

"Nonsense! How will they know it's me if I don't wear a dress? Besides, aren't these enchanted to resist stains?"

"Your legs aren't. Step carefully and try not to fall on your face."

Lady Magnolia scoffed and exited the carriage carefully. She took one step into the mud, grimaced, and turned to Ressa.

“Ah. Perhaps the high heels were a mistake. However, we shall endure. General Shivertail, are you ready? I believe the officers have assembled; once we reach the stage it will truly begin in earnest.”

Zel Shivertail sat in Lady Magnolia’s coach and felt his scales tingling. He looked up, and saw Reynold fussing with the carriage. He looked to one side and saw Lady Magnolia Reinhart standing in the mud, peering up at him.

It felt like he was dreaming. Only, as he ducked his head and stepped from the carriage, he knew he wasn’t. He could see Humans in the distance, hundreds of them. All gathered around a wooden platform. They’d seen Lady Magnolia’s carriage of course, and now their faces were turned to him.

Humans. And here he was, a Drake [General], about to lead them. Of course, Zel knew that was the plan. It had been the plan ever since Magnolia had sent him a letter suggesting just that weeks ago. But though he’d replied, though he’d thought of the Necromancer and the Goblin Lord and thought about the need for a Drake-Human alliance...

It still felt like he was dreaming.

“Are you alright, General Shivertail?”

Magnolia might have had a Skill, or else she could see his unease on his face. Zel straightened and felt at his armor. It was light as a feather, yet the fiery-gold metal shone as if internally ablaze. The Heartflame Breastplate made Zel feel warm in the chill air. A relic of his people and he was wearing it.

“I’m fine, Reinhart. Let’s do this.”

She nodded. They began to walk towards the center of the camp, Ressa and Reynold following a few steps behind. Zel scrutinized the closest Humans to him. They looked like officers, sure enough. Soldiers were the same the world over. But this?

It wouldn't be the first time a Drake had gone north. There were quite a few Drakes who'd decided to live in Human lands, for all they were actively discouraged from doing so by the Drake cities. But while they hadn't invaded each other in decades, the Humans and Drakes were still nominally at war.

If a Drake [General] led his soldiers past Liscor or a Human [Lord] moved past the Blood Fields, it might be war again. And yet here he was. And already, the Humans had begun to notice him. Some were pointing, others turning.

Zel strode forwards with Lady Magnolia at his side. He spoke to her as he walked, still feeling as though someone else was taking every step. The world felt like it was...echoing...around him. It was a dream.

But it was real, too. Zel's heart beat faster than it had in years.

"It feels surreal."

"Oh? What part?"

Magnolia looked up towards Zel. Her face was composed as she walked across the muddy ground. Many eyes were on her too. Waiting. She had to feel the momentous nature of what was occurring. But she looked calm. Zel hoped he did, too.

"All of it. You know that my people won't accept this. And yours will probably riot as well. The continent could change from this."

"Of course it will. That is the point, General."

Zel shivered but kept his head high. Now all the Humans were turning and some had recognized him. He heard muffled exclamations in the crowd. His heart was beating too fast.

“Two days ago I was in a small inn outside of Liscor. I ate, I drank...it was peaceful. I could forget I was a [General], then. Here...”

“Yes?”

Magnolia looked sideways at Zel as they approached the stage in the center of the camp. The Drake was silent for a moment.

“What will happen after I speak, I wonder?”

She shrugged, smilingly slightly.

“I believe I will find out. Spies and so forth. But it depends on what you say. They are waiting for you, General. Are you ready?”

Now all the Humans were looking at him. Zel put his foot on the first wooden step. The wooden stage was simple, but solidly built. Good. That was all he needed. He looked at Magnolia and thought he saw her hands tremble. Just for a second. But then it was gone. She looked him in the eye, fearless. He grinned then, and felt the dream break.

This was reality. Zel offered Magnolia a claw and she took it. They ascended to the top of the stage together. Zel looked over a sea of faces. Human faces. He thought of a young woman named Erin Solstice, of a [Barmaid] named Lyonette. Of an inn. Of a girl named Ryoka Griffin. Of the Necromancer. Zel’s tail curled slightly and then straightened. He nodded.

“Nothing will be the same. Good. Let’s do this.”

This is what the officers saw. Lady Magnolia and a tall Drake wearing shining armor stood on the stage, flanked by a [Maid] and a [Butler]. It was

Lady Magnolia Reinhart who spoke first. She took a step forwards and spoke in a loud, cheerful voice.

“Good evening.”

Her words were amplified by a spell she carried, or a Skill because they were clearly audible even in the back of the crowd. The officers waited, some seeing her for the first time.

Magnolia Reinhart was neither tall nor thin and lithe. She was not, by her own admission, a dashing beauty, although she was quite pretty. But she did have a presence that eclipsed her body. When she spoke, every eye was on her.

“I am Magnolia Reinhart. No doubt you all know why you have been called here from your respective cities. A Goblin Lord threatens the north. He marches towards Invril as we speak, with an army of tens of thousands. Worse, he raises the undead from each city he destroys. He has slaughtered our people, *my* people for too long. He must be stopped.”

A sound ran through the crowd. No one dared speak, but there was a sighing, a sense of unease. Stop the Goblin Lord? Magnolia gazed from face to face, hers betraying no fear.

“Yes, Lord Tyrion Veltras is assembling his own forces elsewhere. Yes, the Goblin Lord’s army is considerable. It has destroyed two Drake armies already. However, Invril is no plum ripe for the picking. Its people will not be prey to Goblin swords, nor shall it come under attack while I live. That is why you are here. You will repulse the Goblin Lord and destroy his army.”

Now there were voices of dissent. Murmurs—those speaking feared to do more than groan aloud. Ressa shifted in place, her gaze finding those who made noise and piercing them with her glare. Magnolia raised her hand and there was silence.

“I realize many of you have reservations. Only naturally. The army assembled here is, alas, smaller than I had hoped. You all hail from different cities; it is only natural you would feel concern about going into battle against another army without leadership. I am aware of the problem.”

Magnolia paused and Zel waited. His heart had grown calm in his chest—either that, or he could no longer hear it. He waited, knowing what was to come.

“To that end I have asked a suitable [General] to lead this army against the Goblin Lord. He stands before you now. I present to you your commander who will lead you against the Goblin Lord.”

Lady Magnolia stepped to one side. She gestured simply at Zel. He stood, waiting. For a second there was shock, then silence. And then someone began to shout.

“A *Drake*?”

Faces paled, turned red, or changed into expressions of fury as the officers realized what Magnolia was implying. One, a huge man got to his feet. He was shaking as he pointed at Lady Magnolia.

“You asked for a *Drake* to lead us? Have you no shame!? Outrageous! How dare—”

He was cut off as his friends dragged him down. But the discontent was evident in the faces of the soldiers and officers alike. Magnolia concealed her inner emotions as she smiled graciously and nodded to Zel. She raised her voice again, cutting over the shouting from the crowd.

“I will let the General speak for himself. And I will have *silence* until he finishes speaking, is that clear?”

This time her request was not honored. There were still voices sounding off. Magnolia frowned and clapped her hands. The sound her hands made

was soft and suddenly there was silence. No one could speak. They stared up at Magnolia. She looked around, eyes glittering dangerously. Then she smiled.

“Thank you. Now, General, I cede the floor to you.”

She bowed ever so slightly, making the Humans blink and shift in surprise. Zel took two steps forwards and took a breath. This was it. He realized now, dimly, that he hadn’t really prepared a speech. Oh well. He knew what to say. He looked over the ranks of outraged, confused, and skeptical Humans and began.

“Many of you may not recognize who I am. I realize all Drakes look alike to most Humans. However, I am no ordinary Drake. I am a [General]. And as Lady Magnolia has said, I am here to lead you against the Goblin Lord.”

The crowd shifted. Zel could see they were resistant, hostile even. He went on, his voice raised. He needed no Skills or spells to speak to the crowd. He had addressed larger armies, shouted over the roar of the battlefield. This? This was easy.

“To those of you who do not know me: I fought in the First Antinium War and the Second, side by side with Human armies, with Gnoll tribes, and pushed the Antinium back into their Hives. I battled the Goblin King’s armies. I have fought longer than some of you have been alive. Perhaps my history means little to you, but you may know me for one of my deeds. I fought the Necromancer at Liscor. I slew him.”

He thought he had. Zel remembered grabbing Az’kerash, remembered the sensation of tearing him apart—a lie. But of all his feats, this was the one Humans recognized. The one the world had recognized him for. Now all the eyes on him were filled with comprehension. He could hear murmurs, despite Magnolia’s invocation of silence. Yes, they knew him.

“My name is Zel Shivertail.”

A gasp ran through the crowd. And a cry went up, short and sudden. Some of the officers took a step back, others looked around in disbelief. Some appeared stunned. They had heard his name before, yes, but few had expected to ever meet him. He was a figure from history, someone whose name had been shouted from the rooftops during the first and second Antinium Wars. Zel heard the name shouted again and closed his eyes.

Tidebreaker. The Drake [General] who had broken the Antinium advance. Zel Shivertail, the hero of the Antinium Wars. Here, on Human lands.

Now there was true silence, as everyone stared at Zel, wondering what he would say next. Zel looked across the ranks of faces and nodded.

“I am here at Lady Magnolia Reinhart’s request. To do battle against the Goblin Lord.”

“Why?”

The shout came almost at once. Zel saw a man in poor armor shouting up at him. Of course. He was a Human and Zel was a Drake general, an enemy [General]. It didn’t matter that he was a low-level officer. Humans had their pride, like Drakes. They wouldn’t suffer an enemy [General] leading them, even if Magnolia ordered them. It was Zel’s job to convince them otherwise.

So Zel answered the man simply.

“The Goblin Lord is here. He is coming. Perhaps not for your city, sir, but for Invisil. He has destroyed villages and towns and cities already. His army grows. You have heard that he defeated two Drake armies? Well, we sent two armies against him, both led by high-level [Generals]. Both were destroyed down to the last [Soldier].”

Silence. Zel looked around.

“I don’t have to tell you all what that means. An army grows from its victories, and the Goblin Lord has only won his battles. He also has an army of the undead that has grown with every slaughter. And he is *coming*. Why am I here? Because he must be stopped.”

Now Zel’s voice rose. He walked down the wooden stage, looking from face to face.

“I am a Drake. You are Humans. I understand that. But when I looked north, after the Goblin Lord had passed Liscor, I saw no Humans rushing to destroy him. I hear Lord Tyrion Veltras is forming a grand army. If so, that is commendable. But he is too late. And he is too far. He is not *here*. In a day or two, the Goblin Lord’s army will be upon Invril. Will Lord Tyrion wait and watch another Human city destroyed? Will he allow tens, no, *hundreds* of thousands of civilians to be slaughtered?”

No one responded. Of course, that was what would happen if they didn’t defeat the Goblin Lord here. Invril was Magnolia’s holding. If it was attacked she would lose influence and Tyrion would gain. That was politics. And it was shameful. Zel put all the scorn he could into his voice.

“That is not right. It is not acceptable. Drakes defend their own when they are attacked. So do Humans. And when Lady Reinhart asked me to lead the defense of her city, I agreed. Not because I am abandoning my people, or because I will be paid. No. Because it is the right thing to do. This is Human land, yes. But this is my continent. This is our *home*. And I will defend it to my death.”

Face to face. Zel looked into eyes and saw they were like Drake eyes. Different, yes, but his words struck some chord in his audience. He went on.

“Drakes do not run. That was a...favorite saying of a friend of mine. It seems it’s become the expression that defines my people. But from what I’ve seen, Humans don’t run either. When the Goblin King landed on your shores, you didn’t flee his armies. Over a million Goblins invaded Izril and still, your people refused to run. You fought. And you were not alone. From every continent, other nations, other people sent their armies to fight. You fought shoulder-to-shoulder with Gnolls, Drakes, half-Elves, Dwarves... together. And when we fought *together*, Izril was undefeatable! I should know. I saw it all. I was there.”

Memory. The Second Antinium War. Burning skies filled with smoke and flame. Goblins, the undead, the Antinium marching from every corner of the continent. Some of the men and women below had lived through those times, or had grown up in them. He saw them shudder, and then saw the burning in their eyes. Yes, that was what he wanted. Zel stopped and pointed at them. He roared across the crowd, his voice thunder.

“This is your home! This city may not be yours, but every city here was built by Humans. You claimed these lands. You spilled blood for them and held them against Drakes, Goblins, the Antinium, and every other threat that sought to claim them for thousands of years. Now the Goblin Lord marches north, his armies growing with every victory. Will you give him another city, the lives of your people? The Humans I know would not do that! The Humans I know would drive his army into the sea and fight till their dying breaths before they gave ground to their enemy!”

There was a growing momentum in the crowd, a shifting. Backs straightened, eyes locked on Zel’s. He looked at them. Soldiers. That was all. They were all the same.

“Drakes squabble. The Human nobility argue. But [Soldiers] fight. We do our duty and then we go home. Well, I am no [Lord]. My own people think I’m troublesome because I think we shouldn’t be at war with your

people. I'm no politician; I'm a soldier like you all. And I see the enemy. Now, I don't know what you think of me, but there's no Tyrion Veltras here. No other [Lord] or [General]. Just me. And I won't retreat until the Goblin Lord's army is shattered and his undead are buried in the ground again! *I will fight!* But I cannot do it alone! Will you do the same?"

Zel raised one fist and stared across the sea of Humans. He waited. He had given them no grand speech, no rousing promise of victory. He had spoken to them like soldiers and now he waited. What if they said nothing? What if they refused? Would it all fail? Were they too alike? What if—

A voice rose in the crowd. At the back, Zel saw a man in battered iron armor raise his voice. He shouted as heads turned, his eyes blazing with emotion.

"I am [Lieutenant] Gershal of Vaunt! I will fight with you, General Shivertail! We do not run from Goblins! I will protect Invril with my men if you will lead us!"

His voice rang out in the silence, proud and alone. It was what Zel had been waiting for. Because on the heels of his declaration came another voice. A woman, standing next to him raised her fists.

"My cavalry will ride with any man, Drake, or Gnoll against a common foe! I pledge my unit to your command!"

"And I!"

An officer next to her unsheathed his sword, nearly cutting the man beside him. More Humans spoke up. A [Lord] stood and shouted.

"For Invril! I will fight to defend the city! I pledge my warriors to Lady Reinhart's army!"

"I will follow any [General], Drake or Human, to defeat the Goblin Lord!"

And then the voices became a shout. Zel waited, standing atop the podium, as the officers and soldiers gathered began to shout his name.

“Shivertail! Shivertail!”

“Tidebreaker!”

And last, but most importantly, a word. Not his name, not a word that represented Zel or Magnolia. The word Zel had been waiting for.

“Izril!”

“Izril! The Dragonlands! The unconquered!”

“Izril!”

And then there was cheering. Officers shouted, swept up in a fury to defend their homes. Zel stood on the platform, absorbing their energy. This was the key. They had been disunited before. Now they had a common enemy. They were an army, however disparate. He waited until the cheering had settled and then gave orders.

“Prepare for battle. We will engage the Goblin Lord if he comes any closer to the city. If he goes around, we will pursue and drive him into a corner. But I promise you this: he will burn no more villages, despoil no more lands. This army will be his end. Officers, I will begin assembling you into groups within the hour. Prepare yourselves; I will assign commands based on rank and level. When we go into battle, it will be as one united force.”

Zel turned as the cheering began again. That didn’t matter. The fact that they’d accepted his command, that they’d agreed to be led by him was all that mattered. He could sort the rest out later. Now...

He walked towards Magnolia, Ressa, and Reynold. They were applauding him with the others. Zel glanced at Magnolia and she descended

the wooden platform with him. They walked through ranks of officers, Zel exchanging words with them, reassuring, standing tall, showing them he was worthy of being followed, until they had a moment to speak.

“I’ll stay here. I’m leading this army now; I’ll stay in the camp.”

“I thought you’d say that. There is a tent waiting and I believe Reynold has a number of lists for you. I will retire to my estate for a while to let you sort things out. Well done, General. Did you use a Skill to impress the crowd so?”

Magnolia paused as she got into her carriage with Ressa driving. Zel shook his head.

“I did not. A Skill might let me drag the army blindly into battle, but it won’t last. I need an army willing to fight, not a bunch of unwilling soldiers.”

“Hm. Interesting. Well, it was quite a rousing speech you gave. Lord Tyrion is not *here*. I would quite like to see his face when he hears that.”

Magnolia chuckled. Then she paused.

“Still, I do think you could have given a more rousing speech. All the quiet moments and the pauses—I should have liked a bit more *vim* to it all. A bit of shouting perhaps? What do you think, Ressa? I give it six points.”

Zel stared at Magnolia as she turned to her maid. Ressa tilted her head, thinking. She nodded at Zel as she replied.

“Four out of five. Not the sort of speech you give on the precipice of a battle, but stirring enough.”

Both women looked at Reynold. The [Butler] flushed and stroked his mustache furiously.

“I’d ah, give it a hundred points out of a hundred, milady, Miss Ressa.”

He avoided their accusatory looks with his eyes and bowed slightly to Zel, speaking to the Drake [General].

“You said what they needed to hear. None of the soldiers here want to risk their lives for glory or believe in noble causes. But defending home and family? They understand that. I felt...inspired myself.”

“Typical. I suppose I’d have to be a [Soldier] to appreciate a speech like that. Come on Ressa, let’s leave General Shivertail to his work. I will speak to you tonight, General.”

“I’ll look forward to it.”

Zel lied as he watched the carriage drive away. He turned and saw Reynold waiting for him, as well as a number of officers.

“I never expected to be cheered. I hoped I wouldn’t be shouted off the stage. If this was a Drake army, I’d have been wary about being dragged off were I a Human.”

Reynold smiled at Zel.

“We Humans are a bit more impressed by titles, sir. And you *are* a hero. When I was younger, I heard of the Tidebreaker slaying the Necromancer in battle. There were celebrations in the streets when it was announced. We remember, sir.”

He coughed, turning a bit red and Zel smiled. Then his smile faded. The Necromancer. The Drake shook his head.

“I’ll try to live up to expectations, Reynold. Now, let’s meet these officers. We have a lot of work to do.”

He strode forwards. And the Humans came to meet him. And even as Magnolia’s coach drove away, rumors were already flying by [Message]

spell and people running towards the city. There was a Drake [General] leading Humans. And not just any Drake.

Zel Shivertail, the Tidebreaker.

The world might never be the same.

Lady Magnolia sat in her carriage, scraping mud off her high heels onto a cushion. Ressa, sitting in the driver's seat, frowned over her shoulder.

"Stop that. Maids will have to clean all that up."

"I hate mud, Ressa."

"Don't make me come back there."

"*Fine*. What did you think of General Shivertail's speech, Ressa? Truly?"

The [Maid] turned back to the road and twitched the reins. The carriage dodged around a convoy of wagons as the [Wagon Driver] in front screamed and raised his hand as if that could stop the oncoming impact.

"Just what I said. It wasn't a flashy speech, but it did the job."

"Mm. I still prefer his famous 'Defiance on the Roshharn Plains' speech, or the 'Liscorian Address'."

Magnolia was unconvinced. She grumbled to herself as she settled back into her seat. But then she brightened as she glanced over her shoulder.

"I say, there's a woman on horseback racing towards Invisil. Do you think they're already starting to gossip?"

“I imagine so. I saw several using artifacts. Word is probably already spreading about Zel Shivertail’s speech.”

“Oh good. I do so love an enthusiastic audience. Speaking of which... you have the recording?”

“On the cushion. The spell caught most of his words perfectly, although the angle was slightly off.”

Magnolia found the small crystal Ressa had mentioned and touched it. Instantly, a projection of Zel sprang into life, and his voice echoed throughout the carriage. She stopped the magical memory with a finger and sighed happily.

“I think I’ll put this one in my personal collection. After we copy the spell and sell it of course. How much do you think I should tell my agents to charge for it? A thousand gold pieces for each copy?”

“The first one will earn the most.”

“Mm. I wonder who pays most for this sort of information? Ah, well, I suppose any worthwhile [Informant] would sell to multiple sides at once. Hurry up now, Ressa; I want to be the first to sell the information about Zel!”

“I’m hurrying. I can’t control this thing as well as Reynold, though. I nearly killed that man on the road just there.”

The coach drove onwards. Magnolia settled back into her seat, already plotting how to disseminate the information about this new alliance in ways that would profit her. But she broke off from her calculations and looked out the window back towards the camp.

She smiled.

“A Drake [General] leading a Human army. Isn’t that something? It’s like a story. Or a dream, I suppose.”

Ressa’s voice was muffled from her position in the front, but it still conveyed a bit of emotion in her words.

“Yes. You did it, Magnolia.”

“At last. We finally took a step. At last.”

Magnolia smiled with genuine happiness. Then she laughed.

“And what *will* they say about it? Oh Ressa, the world is changing.”

And within the hour, word was spreading by spell and bird and foot. And the world took notice.

Important events were subjective across the world. Obviously news like the return of the King of Destruction was worthy of worldwide reporting, but even then, the news of his return was not nearly so vital in Rhir as it was in Chandrar. Thus, gossip about the latest marriage between royals or wars won or magical artifacts unearthed travelled at varying speeds depending on how useful it was.

But in certain circles any news of political value was transmitted instantly from nation to nation. The latest developments on the world stage could be worth hundreds or *thousands* of gold pieces—but of course, such news decreased exponentially in value every minute. And again, few individuals in Baleros were willing to pay for news about Terandrian politics, however dramatic.

But news about a Drake allying with a Human? Much less a Drake whose name was known around the world and a Human woman who could boast the same? *That* was news worth thousands of gold pieces to some. And Magnolia Reinhart's informants earned a lion's share in the hours after Zel had addressed his army.

And as luck would have it, one of those informants spread word to Olesm. Of course he couldn't afford to pay in gold for the news; he could only afford silver. But he still got the news by [Message] spell, and within ten minutes he'd called an emergency meeting of Liscor's council.

Watch Captain Zevara strode into the room at the same time as Wall Lord Ilvriss. Olesm was already there, having beaten them by about a minute. He was panting, his eyes wide, and when he turned to them both Drakes knew the news was serious.

"Out with it."

Ilvriss didn't wait for the rest of the Council to assemble. He was dressed in armor and looking more alert than Olesm had seen him in days, if slightly hung over. Olesm was grateful for that. The Drake nervously lifted the folded bit of parchment and read out loud from it.

"T-this is the news I just received from Invrissil. It came by one of my informants—I'm sure it's trustworthy. Here's what it says. Zel Shiverail, the famous Lineholder General, the Tidebreaker and hero of two Antinium Wars...has formed an alliance with Lady Magnolia Reinhart. He has assumed command of a Human army gathered around Invrissil and is preparing to destroy the Goblin Lord's army—"

Olesm choked on his words. Ilvriss gaped at him. Zevara went to go sit down and missed her chair. She landed with a crash on the ground. Olesm winced as the Watch Captain stared at him. Then Zevara shouted.

"*What?*"

“It’s what it says!”

Olesm flinched as Zevara leapt to her feet. The Watch Captain grabbed the parchment and read it herself. Ilvriss didn’t come over. Instead, he stared at Olesm with a pale face. He seemed almost...calm, which put him at odds with Olesm’s state of near-panic.

“You’re sure of this?”

“I can’t imagine my informant would lie or exaggerate something like this. They’d never be trusted again—the news is everywhere, Wall Lord! That’s what General Shivertail meant when he left—what do we do?”

“Do? He’s gone to the Humans! There’s nothing to do Olesm, he—he’s allied with Magnolia Reinhart? Why would he—just for the Goblin Lord?”

Zevara crumpled the parchment with her fist, looking confused and distraught. Ilvriss looked at her, and then at the first Drakes filing into the room.

“This situation is serious. Olesm, brief the other council members. I am returning to my inn. I need to retrieve a magical artifact.”

“Why? Uh, I mean, why, sir?”

Ilvriss paused, his claw already on the doorframe.

“This requires direct consultation with my peers. And I think, the rest of the continent. Prepare yourself and get me every map and piece of information you can on the Goblin Lord and Reinhart’s forces. This will be a long meeting.”

Then he disappeared out the door. Olesm looked at Zevara, and then he ran for his office.

“This is Ilvriss. Do you hear me?”

“We hear you...Wall Lord. We have an image of you, but it is unstable. The spell seems to be working, however. Proceed.”

Ten minutes later, Wall Lord Ilvriss was standing in the meeting room, speaking into a crystal orb the size of his fist that had been placed on the table. Olesm stood against the wall clutching rolls of parchment. He stared into the orb with wide eyes. The magical ball was reflecting another room, a grand chamber that kept wavering in and out of focus. But what it showed was clear enough.

A room full of sixty or so Drakes were all seated in a round chamber, on benches arranged into a semi-circle. They were all dressed in rich clothing or armor, and each one of them was looking towards Ilvriss. Olesm was scared to even breathe. These were the nobility of Salazsar, the ruling elite of the Walled City. Each one was a Lord of the Wall or a Lady of the Wall, and they were all staring *at him*. Well, not at him, but at Ilvriss, but the pressure alone was making Olesm nervous.

Ilvriss seemed at ease talking with his peers. Indeed, his voice was the only calm one in the room at the moment. He walked back and forth in front of the orb, speaking loudly.

“There isn’t much else I can elaborate on. Zel Shivertail is *gone*. I mentioned as much by [Message] spell, and you received the news about his alliance with Magnolia Reinhart before me.”

“But you were with him two days ago, Ilvriss! You have to know *why* he changed sides!”

The voice that came through the orb was angry, but distorted. Ilvriss grimaced and shifted the orb and the voice warped and warbled. Olesm

looked at him and Ilvriss shook his head. Zevara muttered into his ear.

“Bad connection. Looks like the magic spells are faded or there’s some interference. This is as good as we’ll get.”

Magical communication was very tricky. [Message] spells were common, true, but actual real-time conferences were extremely difficult to organize. And while Wistram could devise any number of complex spells to facilitate conversations, everyone else had to get inventive.

The way Ilvriss spoke to the other Lords and Ladies of the Wall in his city of Salazar was by using a scrying orb. It gave him a view of their conference room while they did the same to him. Both orbs were extremely expensive and, it had to be said, annoying to use. Ilvriss already had a headache as he stared into the small orb and saw a distorted, fish-eye view of a room full of Drake nobility staring back at him.

“I can’t speak to Shivertail’s thoughts. You know he came north pursuing information about the Goblin Lord. And he was delayed in Liscor due to the Antinium...situation.”

“Ah yes. Was his departure related to that, do you think?”

Ilvriss paused before he replied. Another issue was that the use of two scrying spells meant that their conversations were completely public if anyone wanted to listen in. Ilvriss kept his replies as devoid of confidential information as possible.

“Our findings with the Antinium were unusual and troubling...but not unduly so. Whatever threat they might pose, it’s clear that General Shivertail thought the Goblin Lord was a far more important threat.”

“I see. But then *why* would he ally with Humans? And with *her* of all people?”

“I don’t know. But it seems futile to speculate. These are the facts, Wall Lord Menoss. What we should be focusing on is what will happen next.”

Ilvriss gritted his teeth and kept his tail from lashing. Zel Shivertail’s alliance with Lady Magnolia wasn’t an issue solely important to the Drakes in Salazsar of course. No doubt every Walled City was in a panic right now. And for good reason!

“He really went over to Magnolia Reinhart’s side? This isn’t some—some ruse of hers, is it?”

“All indications are that it is not. Zel Shivertail has decided to ally himself with Humans. He has defected, Wall Lady Rizzia.”

There was a pause from the other end. Ilvriss subtly adjusted the orb and a few Drake faces swam into focus. One spoke up, looking worried.

“He can’t do that. Shivertail’s always been an agitator, but this? We must have him back.”

“Have him back? That traitor?”

“Well, he *is* a [General]. He’s one of ours, he can’t just—”

“He’s not *ours*. He’s part of the Trisstral Alliance. I wonder what those cities think of this. If they authorized his departure, they’ll have another thing coming—”

The other Drakes were arguing amongst themselves. Ilvriss ground his teeth together. They were missing the point! He slapped a claw on the table and there was a sudden silence.

“Lords and Ladies, please! Forget about the reasons. Instead of thinking of Zel Shivertail’s actions as a matter of dissent, look at it another way. The highest-level Drake [General] in the *entire world* has just gone over to the Humans’ side.”

The room—both rooms—fell silent. Ilvriss stared around at the suddenly grey faces and nodded.

“Zel Shivertail has never gotten himself involved in politics. He’s a career soldier and one of the reasons why we can afford to fight amongst ourselves. If he starts leading Human armies or worse, participates in battles on their side—”

“He wouldn’t do that.”

“Wouldn’t he? Why not? He has nothing to lose here! We’ve refused to hear him more times than I can count. What’s stopping him from joining with Humans who will give him an army and backing? Face the facts! We have just *lost* our best [General]! We shouldn’t be arguing over the politics, but looking to our safety!”

Ilvriss’ words caused a hush. Olesm held his breath, thinking of all the ramifications. True, no one [General] was influential enough to define the Drake cities or weaken them too much in their absence, but on the other hand...if the Antinium attacked or another nation invaded, it was widely assumed Zel Shivertail would be the first to lead Drake armies in defense. More than that, he was a symbol. People felt reassured—he had beaten the Antinium in two wars after all! If he was gone...

Ilvriss was speaking. Olesm wrenched himself back into listening mode. The Wall Lord was the voice of reason today, which was surprising. Had he really changed that much from his time at Erin’s inn?

“Well if anyone could do it, it would be Erin.”

Olesm mumbled to himself and got a jab from Zevara for speaking. Ilvriss went on.

“I suggest we first contact the other Walled Cities to hear their reaction. And then we reach out to General Shivertail. Otherwise he may decide to

stay in the north after he's finished crushing the Goblin Lord."

There was a pause as the nobles in Salazsar considered his words and then one of the Wall Lords closest to the orb spoke.

"We shall reach out to the other cities and attempt to begin a larger discussion. Wall Lord Ilvriss, please hold."

"I will do so."

The orb went dark and Ilvriss sighed. There was an audible exhalation of breath around the room and Ilvriss looked at Liscor's city council. They were [Merchants] and low-level officials, and they looked, to Olesm, like they were going to be sick. Discussions of this level were several grades above them. However, Ilvriss seemed to regard Olesm and Zevara as worthy sources of input. He turned to them.

"Shivertail's absence is panicking my people. No doubt it will cause trouble elsewhere, but the question is how much damage it will do abroad. Thoughts?"

"No one's going to invade Izril just because Zel Shivertail is gone. We're most at risk of trouble coming from the Humans. However, we might be pressured by foreign powers. We need a united front."

Zevara replied first and Olesm nodded. Ilvriss nodded absently as well and Olesm dared ask the question that was probably bubbling at the top of everyone's minds.

"Do *you* know why General Shivertail would work with the Humans, Wall Lord?"

Ilvriss blinked, looked up, and shrugged.

"Why not? That idiot has talked for years about the need for an army to fight the Antinium, for a united front with the Humans. It shouldn't surprise

you that he'd do this."

"But the Humans—he'll be called a traitor! And he's a hero! I just can't see why..."

Olesm trailed off. Ilvriss looked at the young [Tactician] and shook his head.

"A hero. I forget I'm in Liscor. The facts aren't so straightforward, young Swifttail. True, Zel Shivertail is a hero of the Antinium Wars. No one denies that. But as to his influence among our people...he's been the target of a number of smear campaigns among the Walled Cities over the years. He's been called a rabble-rouser, a traitor for opposing the war with the Humans, and more. Not in Liscor; your city would probably hang anyone who spoke a word against him. But he's been a target for years by politicians."

"But that's just—"

Olesm broke off before he said something that could get him in trouble. Ilvriss smiled bitterly, sensing what Olesm was going to say.

"It's funny. After all these years, he may be more popular among Humans than he is among Drakes. And now, having lost him, every city in the south is looking over their tails nervously."

He shook his head and looked back towards the orb. He muttered under his breath, loud enough for Olesm and Zevara to hear.

"What a mess. Periss was right. We can't keep doing this."

"Sorry, sir?"

"Nothing."

Ilvriss looked up, and he was all business again. He nodded to the orb.

“Shivertail’s out of touch for now. I doubt he’ll respond to any [Message] spells at the moment...what we can do is work on things from our own end. Getting idiots to do what we want is a good start. Fear and paranoia move politics far faster than anything else, Swifttail. Give them a few more minutes to stew before you open the communication spell again.”

“Yes sir.”

Olesm busied himself with laying out maps on the table, just in case. Ilvriss sighed, reached for a goblet full of wine, and stopped himself at the last moment. He looked around, found a cup full of water and picked it up. He stared gloomily into it and then turned as the orb flickered into life. He bared his teeth as Olesm backed away from the orb.

“Time to get to work, Swifttail. There’s no room for error or weakness here. The world is watching.”

And indeed, the world was paying attention. Although how each group reacted was a separate matter entirely.

In Rhir, the news of Zel Shivertail’s alliance with Lady Magnolia hit the court of the Blighted King just past lunch. Most of the diners were in the banquet hall and received the news from the [Herald] with polite amazement or frowns. But a group of Drake [Soldiers] sitting at a table reacted explosively to the news.

“He did *what?*”

One of the Drake [Commanders] leapt up from his table, ignoring the eyes on him. He roared in outrage as the trembling [Herald] repeated the announcement.

“That traitor! He’d ally with Humans? And for what? To stop a Goblin Lord? Let the Humans take care of it! That tailless, backstabbing—”

“Shut up you *newt*!”

A fist smacked the first Drake in the face as another Drake rose. He knocked the first Drake down with a punch and raised his voice.

“General Shivertail’s a hero! If the Tidebreaker’s a traitor then your entire damned Walled City is full of backstabbing worms! Zel Shivertail is doing what he’s always done—protecting our home!”

“Protecting it by siding with the Humans!”

“Yes! Yes! This is what I’ve been saying all along! We need to fight together! The Humans aren’t a threat! If we work together, we can eradicate the Antinium. And a Goblin Lord? Ancestors, does anyone want another Goblin King? Huh? No! Shivertail’s working with Magnolia Reinhart—”

“That traitorous Human can’t be trusted!”

“Better her than the infighting idiots of your city!”

“You take that back!”

“Make me! I’m with the Tidebreaker all the way! He’s got my support!”

The Drake spun and grabbed one of the banners at his table that marked his delegation. He started shouting as he got up on the table and began waving the banner.

“Shivertail! Shivertail! Izril, the greatest continent in the world!”

The rest of the diners in the room stared at the Drake. At the same table Cirille covered her face with her claws.

Across the room, Richard and most of the Humans who’d been summoned to this world sat at a table with some of Rhir’s nobility. They

were confused, but the Rhir nobles around them were mainly contemptuous. One [Lord] shook his head as the Drakes shouted across the banquet hall.

“Drakes. They’re so *noisy*.”

“Izril!”

The Drakes argued and fought until they were ejected from the banquet hall. They were all commanders and over two thirds supported Zel Shivertail. As for the rest of Rhir, the news wasn’t as important. Drakes? Humans? They were on another continent. If it meant more aid to Rhir, all the better. Otherwise, it mattered little. On Baleros, however, the opinion was sharply different. At least, for one Fraerling.

“Play it again.”

Niers Astoragon was still in his night clothes, but the messenger had dragged both him and Foliana out of their beds. He scrubbed at his face, willing the fatigue to vanish as he listened to the recording of Zel speaking.

“Dead gods. And this is going out across the world? It will upset the entire balance in Izril. What is that Reinhart woman thinking?”

“Mm. Probably that this is a good idea. Tidebreaker vs Goblins. Bad for Goblin Lord. Good for her.”

Foliana perched on a couch, staring at the image of Zel Shivertail. Niers stared too.

“The Tidebreaker. A [General] like that allied with someone with the Reinhart fortune behind her...that’s a dangerous combination.”

“Only if they do bad things.”

“That’s practically a given, isn’t it? Magnolia Reinhart isn’t known for mercy. But Zel Shivertail agreed to help her? Maybe that means he—”

Niers broke off. He stared around. They were in his room and he was sitting on his desk. Unbidden, his eyes went to the gold-encrusted letter that Magnolia had sent him. Foliana noticed the look.

“Magnolia Reinhart sends me letters every month. Mm. Yesterday she sent me a letter and a muffin.”

The Fraerling [Strategist] looked up sharply.

“You didn’t eat it, did you?”

“Mm...”

“*Foliana!* There are more spells and poisons than we can test for—”

“It had blueberries in it. And lots of sugar. And she sends you letters too.”

“Yes, and I don’t *eat* my letters!”

“So? You read them. Which is worse?”

Niers choked but couldn’t reply. He stared at the letter and listened to Zel speaking in silence.

“Defending home, huh? Doing the right thing. I’d never expect to hear someone allied with Magnolia Reinhart saying that—no, I suppose that’s exactly what she’d say. Only I believe it, coming from him.”

“Reinhart defends her home. Did it in the last Antinium War.”

“Yes, but that was—she’s not the same as him.”

“No. But they both fight for their home. You did, too.”

Foliana turned vaguely accusing eyes to Niers and he looked away.

“Curiosity. That was all, Foliana.”

“Mm. Well, maybe he was curious.”

“Who?”

Foliana pointed at the tiny Drake standing in the magical crystal on the table.

“Him. Maybe he was curious.”

Niers fell silent. He didn't see Foliana leaving, but he knew she was gone after a while. The Titan sat on his table, replaying the image of Zel speaking again and again, late into the night.

On Chandrar, various individuals took note of the politics in Izril, but only a few were in any position to care. One, the Emperor of the Sands, considered that the move was unfortunate for his nation since it had the potential to strengthen Izril.

The other, the King of Destruction, was mainly confused.

“Who?”

“The Tidebreaker, my King.”

Orthenon spoke in front of Flos' throne. The King of Destruction frowned.

“Tidebreaker? The title seems vaguely familiar, but I cannot place it. This Tidebreaker is a Drake [General]?”

“Yes, a famous one. You may not recognize him because he rose to prominence after your slumber, my liege. He defeated the Antinium during two wars and fought the Goblin King and the Necromancer himself. He is considered to be the highest-level [General] the Drakes possess.”

“Interesting.”

Flos’ eyes lit up and a smile crossed his face.

“He sounds fascinating. I suppose this alliance bodes well for Izril, does it?”

Orthenon paused.

“It could. On the other hand, it could result in turmoil if the Drakes and Humans enter conflict over his switching allegiances. Either way, I do not think this is fortunate news for us. A [General] of his level allied with Magnolia Reinhart is a considerable threat.”

“I am aware. It seems this Goblin Lord is outmatched. A pity. I always wanted to meet a Goblin King.”

“Do not jest please, Your Majesty.”

“Who says I’m jesting? Ah, come now Orthenon. I missed the Goblin King and they only appear every few centuries! What a disappointment. Come to think of it...be sure to instruct Trey and Teres about the Goblin King, would you? That is an important battle to remember.”

“I shall, Your Majesty. Now, while the news is important, I do not predict it will affect the situation locally in any significant way. If General Shivertail strengthens his alliance with Magnolia Reinhart we may run into trouble when coming into conflict with Izril, but that is far enough away to be safely ignored for now. For more pressing concerns, we seem to have rats in one of the granaries. I would not trouble you with the news, but it seems these rats can teleport, so I would request...”

Flos sighed as he leaned back on his throne. Chandrar was safe. The other continents listened to the news from Izril, but with no real alarm. Only interest and sometimes scorn.

“It would be one of the Reinharts that would agree to such an alliance.”

“Indeed. Allying with a Drake against Goblins? Has she no shame?”

“Then again, the Reinharts have always been a meddlesome family.”

“Indeed. Indeed.”

“I suppose the news is important, however obliquely. I would rather see the Veltras family succeed than the Reinhart house. They at least object to the presence of Drakes.”

“True. An embargo may be called for. Tariffs at the least to express our discontent.”

“It will be a matter for debate. Let us see what the other kingdoms do first.”

“Hm. I suppose.”

In Terandria, scorn was everywhere. Not that it was particularly informed scorn; it was more of a neighborly disdain for everything they regarded as inferior. Teriarch sighed as he cut short the conversation between two Terandrian nobles with a wave of his claw.

It wasn't hard for the Dragon to intercept communications between mages and magical artifacts, even the encrypted ones. That was the problem with mages of today. They were so, so...complacent. Every spell was the same, which meant all the flaws were the same too.

The Dragon sighed. If he tried, he could actually *hear* the reports about Zel Shivertail's alliance with Magnolia passing across the world. So much news and over so little! All he'd done was ally with her. It wasn't the first time Humans and Drakes had worked together.

"But perhaps it is significant for this age. When was the last time they formed an alliance? A hundred years ago? No. Four hundred? Wait, there was that marriage—hrm. Hmf. I suppose it *is* important. No wonder Reinhart is bothering me so."

Teriarch flicked a claw, dismissing the [Message] spells he'd received from Magnolia. He sighed again and curled up a bit more in his cave.

"What was it she said? A [General], a [Strategist], and me? Pah. That hatchling's barely a [General]. I suppose he's of a decent level, but as for his speeches, I'll pass. Good speeches have more fire to them. When *I* was young, I heard some good ones. How did the one with the Human in purple armor go again? Something about eating the tails of their foes? Or did the Gnoll say that? Hm..."

The Dragon trailed off blankly and curled up in his cave. Another [Message] spell appeared and he flicked it away with a twitch of his tail.

"Not yet, girl. Not yet. One isn't two and besides, I promised nothing. You think you can order Dragons around? We're...very noble species... unacceptable. Going outside is...quite dull...anyways."

His voice grew lower and sleepier as Teriarch drifted into a nap. He slept, as the world panicked. He had seen it all before and would see it all again. There were no surprises for immortals. Not for those beyond death.

“What?”

Az’kerash froze, one hand outstretched over the heap of flesh and bones. Ijvani shuffled her feet, disliking the surprise she saw written over her master’s face.

“Zel Shivertail has taken command of an army formed by Magnolia Reinhart, Master. He is preparing to defend Invril from the Goblin Lord’s attack or pursue his army should the Goblin Lord avoid the city.”

“Shivertail? Ally with a Human? Impossible. How can that—”

Az’kerash abandoned the grisly remains on the table and began to pace back and forth. He was visibly shaken by the information, but as he paced, his agitation disappeared and a calculating look passed over his face instead. The black skeleton was relieved to see that. She waited while the Necromancer mused out loud.

“Is this an opportunity or a trap? No—if Shivertail has given me this opportunity, I must seize it no matter how remote the chances of success are. Thank you, Ijvani. Now—”

He flicked a hand and muttered a spell. The air opened up and Ijvani saw Az’kerash speaking to the air.

“My apprentice. Heed my words now.”

Across the world, the news of Zel’s alliance was heard, but it could be argued it mattered little to most. In Izril, the news sent Lord Tyrion Veltras into a rage and confused a certain blind [Emperor] until the politics of Drakes and Humans were explained to him by a certain Lady Rie Valerund.

It reached the ears of Erin Solstice and made her rub them for a while. But the magnitude of what had happened was only understood by a few.

Klbkch of the Antinium and his Queen were silent at the news. They debated what might occur in hushed tones and thought of the past and the future. Ilvriss convinced his people to avoid denouncing Zel Shivertail outright, and to approach him carefully as well.

But that was all politics and it really didn't matter. For instance, neither Rags and her tribe nor Garen Redfang and Tremborag had any idea of what had occurred. Neither would they have cared, largely. Alliances were all very well, but it was battle that mattered. If an angry Drake [General] was coming their way, no sane Goblin would fight him. They'd just run.

So perhaps the news mattered only to two individuals. A Necromancer and his apprentice. Because as Osthia Blackwing watched the Goblin Lord argue and then kneel in agony to his master, she felt the world change. And as he rose, bitter and furious and tore the map apart, she knew one thing before he turned and spoke.

“We attack Invrisil. We go to slay the one named Zel Shivertail.”

The Goblin Lord spat the words, turning to his lieutenants. The other Goblins stared at him, and Osthia felt her stomach lurch. She spoke and every head turned towards her.

“You won't defeat him. Not General Shivertail.”

The Goblin Lord looked at her, his black eyes and white pupils dilated with rage. His voice shook—the first real display of emotion she'd seen out of him.

“We are ordered. So we will. Or die.”

And so the world turned. Gossip and rumors floated about, but there was only one certainty. Zel Shivertail sat in his tent and felt the certainty

just like the Goblin Lord. He turned his head and the Goblin Lord turned his. Across many miles their gazes locked. And there was only one word on the lips of both.

“Death.”

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S02 – The Antinium Wars (Pt.3)

(This book, *The Second Antinium Wars, a History*, was widely sold across Izril in the years after the Second Antinium War ended. It has been widely criticized and subsequent editions included the Introduction section as well as substantive revisions to the text. The accuracy of the following narrative is not guaranteed.)

Introduction –

The tale of the Second Antinium War may not need writing in this moment. The scars of that great conflict still loom large in the public consciousness, and history may yet reveal details that shed new light on the events during and preceding the war. It is also true that history requires the removal of years to be viewed in an objective light.

However, I, Krsysl Wordsmith, do not wish to wait for the dust to have metaphorically settled. I began writing this book six months after the Second Antinium Wars had ended. I consider this historical narrative a first step towards a full record of the war as a whole. No other history has been written as of yet and one must be made now, before the details of the conflict fade from living memory.

Does it have inaccuracies? Yes! Bias? Perhaps! But my word stands on its own and I will be remembered by history as the first [Writer] willing to collate the scattered viewpoints and accounts of the war into a single, understandable story that future generations can use!

I will not bow to lesser writers or indignant critics who decry my work! I have labored tirelessly in creating a truthful account that is only colored

by my love of people and continent. Regardless of the slanderous attacks on my reputation, I can assure you, good readers, that the following narrative is as true to fact as any history written. I remain humbly and accurately,

—Krsysl Wordsmith

The Second Antinium Wars –

Our tale, dear readers, begins, as it always must, with the species that has become the bane of the civilized world, the nightmare that haunts Izril to this day. The Antinium. Once a distant threat, a mysterious bogeyman race in Rhir used to frighten hatchlings at night. No longer. The previous Antinium War of only eight years ago had seen the upset of power in Izril and the dramatic emergence of a new national power in the appearance of the Antinium.

Their six Hives and foothold in southern Izril remained a threat to all Drakes, Gnolls, and Humans on the continent. Only the hard-won peace kept any sort of balance between the races, and tensions between Antinium and Drakes remained at a boiling point as both sides prepared for what would surely be a second conflict.

Drakes do not forgive. And the Antinium had demonstrated their ceaseless appetite to anyone with eyes. The peace they had agreed to was only a reprieve. Now the world waited with bated breath for one side to loose the opening shot.

The year is 13 A.F. and Izril remains tentatively at peace. The Drake cities, humbled by the Antinium, have rebuilt and strengthened their garrisons. Meanwhile, the Humans to the north have waxed arrogant, untroubled in large part from the last war. Those pompous, tailless fools

neglected to watch their borders, which is how the Second Antinium War grew into the mess it did. But I suppose not all the blame can be assigned to Humans. Some must rest on the Drakes who began the war as a whole. But I get ahead of myself. Some background is essential first.

Before the Second Antinium War began, the world as a whole was not at peace. It never is. And while recording the machinations of each individual nation would interfere with the narrative, it is important to note several events in the world which would directly impact the Second Antinium War in the future.

To begin with, of the five continents in the world, only Izril and Chandrar could be considered calm by any stretch of the word. Chandrar was still recovering from the collapse of the King of Destruction's empire and nations were rebuilding. Or in the case of the emerging Empire of Sands, slowly growing their borders and absorbing smaller nations. However, such conflicts were small and thus Chandrar could be considered peaceful.

Similarly, Izril was at peace, although it was hard-won. The six Antinium Hives and the foothills in their proximity were designated as forbidden zones. The Drake cities sent regular patrols near the borders of the Hives, but save for a few incidents where Drake patrols crossed over the lines and disappeared, there was no military action. Any Antinium found crossing the border were swiftly executed, and while each incident raised tensions, no wider breach of the peace treaties had yet to occur in the eight years since. The continent was peaceful, even if that peace was a façade.

As for Rhir, conflict is a way of life on that continent, and the Blighted King's forces occupied themselves battling the Demons as usual. No, it was Terandria and Baleros where momentous events were occurring.

In Terandria, the Necromancer had appeared once again. This elusive specter of death, the infamous outcast of Wistram, the fallen Archmage, had

plagued the continent for over a century, leading armies of death against the living. He would destroy and despoil kingdoms, his undead armies beaten back only after much effort and then disappear before he could be slain, returning after years or sometimes decades. Each time stronger.

Now he had returned leading a massive army against the port-Kingdom of Desonis. He quickly overwhelmed the kingdom's army but did not approach the capital. Rather, he seized a local port and vanished.

Speculation would run rife about the Necromancer's whereabouts, and Wistram, fearing an attack, would prepare for a conflict with the Necromancer's army. However, incredibly, news of the Necromancer was only a backdrop to the larger event occurring in Baleros. And that was the emergence of the Goblin King.

The Goblin King. To preface speaking about him, I will note the facts that have been observed about such individuals, few though they may be. Goblin Kings emerge every few centuries at most and each time herald destruction and death without fail. They appear to be a naturally occurring phenomenon, a rare individual born out of the Goblin population that has immeasurable talent, much like Goblin Chieftains and Goblin Lords.

However, while those lesser leaders of Goblins can lead small armies and be reasoned with, Goblin Kings are different. Each one is incredibly difficult to kill and lays waste to every civilization they encounter. They lead massive armies formed from Goblins that emerge from every part of the world and flock to the Goblin King's banner.

Only the combined efforts of nations can stop Goblin Kings, which is why almost every nation in the world has signed a treaty which requires their aid in destroying a Goblin King, should one appear. Such is their threat that Goblin Lords are actively hunted down to prevent them from becoming Goblin Kings.

The race of Goblins itself is a threat, but one widely accepted as a recurring nuisance given the perceived impossibility of eradicating their kind permanently. Yet efforts have been historically made to coexist in peace with their kind. This humble writer trusts that the rise of the last Goblin King, known as Velan the Kind, will prove how futile that endeavor is.

In the year of 14 A.F, the Goblin Lord known as Velan the Kind had existed in a peaceful and even harmonious relationship with the nations of Baleros. While his autonomous tribe of Goblins was not recognized as a formal power by most nations in the world, his company of Goblins was regarded as one of the strongest on the continent. It was rumored to be the fifth Great Company of Baleros and Velan's own commitment to peace and trade had earned him the grudging respect of other species. It was hoped his example could be spread to Goblins worldwide, putting an end to Goblin raids and their threat as a species.

Unfortunately, in the waning months of spring, Velan the Kind fulfilled an unknown criteria and ascended or otherwise transformed into a Goblin King. Not much is known about the actual event—only that shortly afterwards Velan the Kind appeared with his entire tribe in the Balerosian city of Zexil and razed it in a single day. In doing so Velan broke eighteen separate treaties of nonaggression.

His army destroyed the city utterly and left no survivors. He then proceeded to execute every messenger sent to him and began razing city after city, his army growing with every battle. His only message to the confused leaders of Baleros was a single word, conveyed by a half-dead Courier.

“Vengeance.”

Thus began the war with the Goblin King, as every company on the continent agreed to a truce to deal with Velan's threat. However, the Goblin

King was joined by many Goblin Lords and their tribes, creating an unassailable force. He seized and leveled the port cities on the eastern side of Baleros and proceeded to construct thousands of ships. He sailed from the continent in the beginning of summer, leaving only destruction in his wake.

That is the setting of the conflict, dear reader. Both the Goblin King and Necromancer occupied the public consciousness at the time. Yet it was the Clash on the Jessal Highlands that would begin things in earnest.

Five days after the start of summer, a Drake army marched past the Antinium's border and laid siege to one of their Hives, catching them by surprise. The army had been formed by three of the Walled Cities and a number of lesser city-states for the sole purpose of exterminating the Antinium once and for all.

On that warm, humid summer's day, the Antinium must have been desperate as a mighty Drake army appeared and proceeded to lay waste to one of their Hives, exterminating the Workers and Soldiers and using rain-based tactics to flood the tunnels of the Hive.

And perhaps they might have succeeded in removing the Hive! I urge you to imagine it, dear readers. If they had succeeded in this first punitive strike then history might recall this as the day the Antinium downfall began. Alas, it was not to be.

“Wow. I thought this was supposed to be a happy story. Hey Klbkch, didn't you say you were reading an appropriate bedtime story?”

Everyone looked up. The Antinium sitting in the barracks of the Painted Soldiers all stared at Erin as she crunched down on some popcorn. Klbkch, who had been chosen to read the book out loud, clicked his mandibles together gently.

“I was under the impression that this ‘bedtime story time’ event was to be undertaken without commentary, Erin.”

He looked around the room at the rows of silent Workers and Soldiers. They sat on the floor, each one cocooned in layers of blankets and pillows. Most of the Antinium had mugs of hot milk and honey in their hands, or bowls of popcorn. Some had roast bees, others fish congee—Erin had outdone herself in preparing for tonight. She had received special permission to come into the Hive itself and participate in the bedtime event.

She just hadn’t realized that *this* was the story Klbkch would choose to read out loud. Erin blamed herself. She should have offered to tell everyone the story of *Winnie the Pooh*, or *Alice in Wonderland*. Instead, they were reading about the history of a war.

“I’m just *saying* that it’s dark, Klbkch! Really dark!”

“I can request more light if you want.”

Pawn turned to Erin, solicitously offering her one of the lanterns scattered around the room. They gave the large barracks a comfortable glow. She sighed.

“Never mind. But are you all really enjoying yourselves?”

She looked around. Belgrade, Anand, Garry, Pawn, and Bird all nodded happily. Bird was playing with his pillow, pulling out feathers and identifying them under his breath.

“Goose. Goose. Goose. Oh. A duck’s feather. I am very content.”

“So are we. I feel warm and comfortable. It is a unique experience to have while resting.”

Anand nodded. He was swaddled in a blanket and crunching on some buttery popcorn. Erin turned to her right.

“How about you?”

She addressed a huge Soldier who was nearly engulfed by three blankets and six pillows. The Soldier’s head poked out of his cocoon of blankets, staring at Erin. It was horrifyingly cute or just...horrifying if you couldn’t see past their exoskeletons. Still, Erin thought the Soldier looked comfortable. He was certainly clutching his pillow tightly with all four arms. She smiled at him.

“Aw, okay. You’re good. But I still think this is really violent stuff!”

“Wars usually are. But as I was reading—this writer has a very objectionable description of our species. I was present at the battle and I do not believe the Antinium ‘*trembled like the insects we are*’ or ‘*barely mounted an effective counterattack*’. As I recall, myself and Xrn were the only two Prognugators close enough to respond. We marched on the attacking Drake army and found them dug into the area. They had created a kill zone with [Mages] and [Archers] and a wall of [Spearmen]. We could only assault them head on, which is what they desired. It was...unpleasant.”

“You were there, Revalantor Klbkch? Will you tell us the story from your perspective?”

Belgrade sat up eagerly, holding a warm mug of milk. Klbkch hesitated.

“There is not much to say. We charged. They held. We charged again. Still they held. And then we charged a third time and they broke. That was all there was to it.”

Klbkch shrugged awkwardly, almost embarrassed by the question. Belgrade looked disappointed.

“Surely there must have been more to it than that. The Drakes were ready for you, were they not? It seems incredible that they would be defeated so easily.”

His observation made Klbkch look down at the book. He casually reached down and tore out a page and crumpled it up into a fist.

“*‘Cowardly attack? A victory of deceptions?’* This book is more inaccurate than I had assumed. No. That is not how we won. Yes, they were ready. Very well, I will relate the story as best I can. The Drakes had provoked our armies into attacking them by striking at our Hive. They had lured us into a trap with no good solution.”

Klbkch’s mandibles clicked together and he shook his head as he stared into the distance. His Antinium audience watched him, spellbound.

“Either we attempted to overwhelm their positions, which was not a given even if we threw all available forces into the battle—or we lost one of our remaining Queens. Naturally, we chose to fight. But the casualties were high. With every wave we sent in, Soldiers were cut down by the thousands by magic and arrow, unable to penetrate the Drake lines.”

He paused, and his mandibles lowered as his voice grew low. Every Soldier and Worker leaned forwards, hanging on his words.

“Xrn and I were desperate, waiting for reinforcements that were too far away, knowing the Queen’s chamber was being flooded, that we had less than an hour before her demise at best. At that moment, I—”

“Popcorn! Get your popcorn here!”

A low voice interrupted Klbkch. Every head turned as Erin marched down the rows of Soldiers, passing out large bowls of popcorn.

“I have hot milk and honey! Lots of it! And snacks! Would anyone like a hot fish or roast Ashfire Bee? Speak up! Or—wave your hands! You sir, you look like you need food! Don’t be shy!”

Erin offered a bowl full of fish congee to a Soldier and looked around.

“What? Am I being too loud? Sorry! I’ll keep it down.”

Klbkch cleared his throat meaningfully with a dull *clicking* sound. He looked around as Erin tiptoed about, ladling soup into bowls and passing around supplemental pillows. Soldiers gently held the pillows, feeling the softness against their chitin—an alien sensation. And they could *keep* the pillows? They didn’t disappear after you slept? Wonders never ceased.

At the head of the room, seated in the one chair, Klbkch opened the book and looked around. The Free Antinium watched him, waiting for him to continue. He nodded slowly.

“It was desperate. We had not expected this assault, and there were but seven Queens left. Seven out of what had been hundreds. You were all created far too late, but once the Antinium had more Queens than Hives. Once we were mighty. Now, we feared losing a single Queen and so we fought desperately. To save her. To save our kind. Xrn and I led this desperate army against the Drakes. If we had had time we could have rallied a larger force. If we had had time, we would have destroyed them easily. But we were out of time. So we paid the cost in the lives of the fallen.”

His voice sharpened. Klbkch gestured, and the Antinium saw the twin swords at his hip shine as he unsheathed them. Klbkch stared at the silvery glow of his sword blades as he spoke.

“Antinium. Listen well. This is the tale of the first battle of the Second Antinium War. This is the tale...of how I met your Queen.”

He paused and looked around the room.

“Obviously I had met her before. But this was our first significant meeting which preceded the creation of Liscor’s Hive. I felt the need to clarify that statement.”

He looked around, shrugged, and began to speak.

Fire from the sky. Death below and above. Lightning blew apart a group of Soldiers as they charged towards the Drake lines; the earth exploded in front of a unit of frantically digging Workers and arrows cut down the rest. Klbkch and Xrn stood on the bluff overlooking the Fourth Hive and the Drake army. Klbkch shook his head as the tide of Soldiers broke against the line of Drake spears.

“We cannot break their formation with a piecemeal attack, Xrn. And they are prepared for our tunneling; they have flooded every tunnel our Workers have dug.”

“And their [Mages] are too powerful. Too many. I cannot fight them at this range. If I focus on one, the others shield with spells and counterattack.”

Xrn agreed, clutching her staff in one slim hand. She conjured lightning and hurled it towards the Drake army. It vanished halfway to her target and a flurry of arrows and spells shot towards both Centenium. The two Prognugators took cover behind a rock, and Klbkch’s mandibles clashed together angrily.

“Oath breakers! They violated the peace treaty! And they are about to flood the Queen out. Xrn, we must launch a full-scale attack.”

“What?”

The azure Antinium turned to Klbkch. She shook her head.

“Impossible. We cannot order the Soldiers into that slaughter! They will break and run, Klbkch! They have their limits.”

“Then I will lead them myself.”

Klbkch grimly raised both his silvery swords with two of his four arms. The other two held daggers awkwardly. Xrn stared at him and grabbed his shoulder.

“Unacceptable. You are still not used to your new body. Don’t throw your life away, Klbkch! If you perish—”

“If I do, enact the Rite of Anastases.”

“You have died too many times! I will not lose you like Rehab or Mellika! One Queen is not worth it, Klbkch! Wait for Wrymvr! When he arrives we will crush the Drakes. But we cannot lose you! You are Centenium!”

Klbkch was silent as the two stood together. He shook his head slowly as he stared down into the battlefield below, where a storm was raining down into the entrance tunnels, flooding the Antinium Hive.

“I was Centenium, Xrn. I lost my form, my levels—we have seven Queens left.”

“And we have but three Centenium. Don’t go.”

Xrn pleaded with him, but Klbkch simply raised his swords. He looked sideways at her.

“Take out as many [Mages] as you can. Stop the rainfall. I will break their lines.”

He strode forwards, towards the head of the Antinium army. Xrn let her arm fall helplessly. She heard Klbkch shouting as the ranks of Soldiers and Workers turned to follow him.

“Antinium! The enemy is attempting to slay a Queen! They are destroying the Hive! They must be stopped! Follow me! Give no ground to

our foe! Charge!”

He charged down the slope and the Soldiers charged after him in a silent wave. Xrn stood on the cliff, frantically shooting down the wave of spells that came from the Drake army, trying to protect the lone Antinium in the front. She saw Klbkch charging across the muddy ground, running into the wall of Drake spears. Then there was a flash of silver—frenzied fighting—falling Soldiers and Workers—

Chaos. The Drakes had not been prepared for a suicidal charge and their front line wavered as their [Mages] and [Archers] enacted a terrible vengeance upon the Antinium. Xrn raised her staff and tried to destroy the enemy Drake [Mages].

“[Venomous Snow]! [Thunderstrike Volley]! [Chaos Flamewheel]!”

Her spells blasted apart Drakes in robes, lightning and jets of fire arcing through Drake lines. But they didn’t break. And an arrow struck Xrn in her chest. She stumbled backwards.

“Not yet.”

She snapped the shaft off, ignoring the blood. The Antinium were wavering. She looked around in desperation and saw thousands of Workers standing around helplessly. Their crude bows did not have the range needed to strike the Drake army from this distance and it would be death to advance any further into the kill zone.

“If it is slaughter, then it must be. Workers! Prepare for a second charge! [Glorious Radiance]!”

Xrn’s spell made the Antinium shine like beacons. She pointed her staff towards the Drake army. She could not see the flash of silver among their ranks. Where was Klbkch?

“Charge!”

A second wave of Antinium charged down the slopes, some of the Workers tripping and falling in the mud. Xrn raced down the slippery incline, hearing thumps as spells blasted the ground around her, hearing only the roar in her mind. Black arrows streaked down towards her forces—she waved her staff and they broke on a shield in the air. The Drakes were ahead of her now.

“Break their ranks!”

Xrn ran past a struggling knot of Soldiers being held at bay by Drakes with spears and swords and planted her staff in the ground. She concentrated and then thrust her fingers forwards.

“[Repulsion Wave].”

The Drakes in front of her—and Soldiers—were blasted into the air. Xrn pointed towards the gap in the lines and the Antinium flooded through. Now the Drake lines were collapsing, but there were still so many! Xrn struggled, fighting other [Mages] hand-to-hand, burning them with spells, until she heard a sound above the noise of battle.

It was a voice, a roar, a screeching that no animal or person could ever make. The piercing cry echoed and made the Drakes look up. Xrn did too, staring towards the north. And then she saw him. She breathed a sigh of relief.

“At last. Wrymvr.”

A dark shadow flew across the sky. A tiny shape—but growing larger with each passing second. The Drakes turned, their [Archers] sighting at this new threat. But then the singular shadow multiplied, and grew, spreading across the horizon.

“The Flying Antinium!”

Xrn shouted, knowing the Drakes had no idea what was happening. They were trying to form a second line to deal with this new threat, but the Antinium were closing in too fast. The dark shapes became visible now, and it was apparent that the Antinium weren't actually flying—they were gliding down, hopping forwards like grasshoppers and propelling themselves with their wings incredibly quickly. Only one figure, larger than the rest, truly flew, and he screeched again, a wordless scream of vengeance.

The Flying Antinium crashed into the Drakes from the side and Xrn raised her staff. The light from her eyes shone bright red, the color of battles and Drake blood. She shouted.

“Charge! Forwards, all Antinium!”

She ran forwards as the Soldiers and Workers crashed into the Drakes like the tide. This time the Drakes could not stop them. Xrn ran forwards as Drakes died, searching, hunting for any color in the black mass. And then she saw it. A flash of silver.

Klbkch.

On that day the Antinium liberated the besieged Hive and the youngest of the Antinium Queens. Klbkch personally rescued her from drowning and she would later go on to lead the hive in Liscor. The Queen of the Free Antinium lived that day, and the Drakes learned to their cost what war with the Antinium was. It was sacrifice. The Antinium could not be broken so easily. And their retaliation for this treachery would soon engulf the continent in flames.

“Did it really happen like that? Truly, Prognugator Xrn?”

Xrn opened her eyes. She looked around the campfire at the other Antinium watching her. Tersk, Pivr, her Prognugator-Guardians, and the other Antinium assigned to her escort were all staring at her. Slowly, the Small Queen looked around and then remembered the book she was holding. She nodded.

“That was what the battle was truly like. We triumphed, but barely. Were it not for Wrymvr’s arrival, we might have been too late to save the Queen.”

“And yet, it appears that Revalantor Klbkch took a great risk in attempting to save her. Did you not say that it would be more prudent to avoid risking his life—and by extension, yours—to save a single Queen?”

Pivr observed as he fanned his own wings at the fire, looking smug about the role the Flying Antinium had played in the battle. Xrn gave him a long look, which deflated Pivr quite nicely.

“Perhaps. But that would not have been in Klbkch’s nature. It was a risk, true. But he has fought for the Antinium longer than *your* Queen has existed, Pivr. He understands sacrifice.”

“And yet, he disregards his worth. The Centenium are a unique group of Antinium that can no longer be reproduced, are they not? Surely Revalantor Klbkch should take his safety into account.”

Tersk spoke up quietly, polishing his armor. Xrn nodded. She played with her staff, twirling it and making the fire change colors as she stared around the night sky.

“Perhaps he should. But again, that is not his nature, Tersk. Klbkch, Wrymvr, and I all served during the Second Antinium War. And while it is true Klbkch lost much of his strength and his original form, we three still defined the war. Each one of us led the armies of the Antinium. Wrymvr and I were unstoppable in battle. As we had been created to be. Klbkch was

forced to lead through strategy rather than personally most of the time. But each of us claimed many victories through our strength.”

Tersk nodded.

“So I understand. But I have never met Prognugator Wrymvr. Is he similar to you or Revalantor Klbkch, Prognugator Xrn?”

The Small Queen hesitated.

“...No. Wrymvr is different. He and Klbkch and I were all created to serve different roles. Klbkch was a warrior, meant to assassinate the Antinium’s enemies and fight on the front. I was meant to cast magic. And Wrymvr was meant to defend the Grand Queen. He was created to be undefeatable.”

“He must be the most powerful of the Centenium, then!”

Pivr looked up, his eyes shining. Xrn’s own eyes flashed purple with annoyance.

“He is a fool. But yes, he is strong. Perhaps that is the only thing this book gets correct. Wrymvr the Deathless was a threat. And in this war the Grand Queen released him from his role as protector. We unleashed him against the Drakes, as well as the Flying and Silent Antinium. It was enough to win a few battles. But unfortunately not enough. If we had more variants, more Centenium, then perhaps we might have won the entire war. But we did not.”

The other Antinium were silent as Xrn opened the book again. Only Tersk dared ask the question hanging in the air.

“Prognugator Xrn?”

“Yes?”

“What *are* the Centenium? Why were they created?”

Xrn stopped with her finger on the next line of the book. She looked around, at the other Antinium. They were so close to home, to their Hives. And yet, these poor copies of true Antinium would never know home, would they? They would never know the grandeur of the true Hives, the might of what the Antinium had been. She looked at Tersk, the finest warrior of his Hive. An ill-made clone of Galuc with armor. She shook her head and her voice was kind as she spoke to him, an adult to a child.

“The Centenium were made long ago, Tersk. Long ago, on another continent. For one purpose. The Grand Queen made many Antinium in many shapes to serve every role imaginable, but one hundred of us she labored upon, gave individuality to, gave names and strength beyond the rest. We were not made to be spent and replaced like the other Antinium. We were made to be one thing and one thing alone.”

“And what was that, Prognugator Xr—”

“*Heroes*, Tersk. We were made to be heroes.”

The battle on the Jessal Highlands ended in disaster. The surprise attack on the Antinium had failed, leaving only regrets and recriminations from the other Drake city-states that had not been aware of the surprise attack. A request to end hostilities was made immediately, but the traitorous Grand Queen of the Antinium, no doubt sensing an opportunity, ignored the pleas of the Drakes and launched a vicious counterattack at once.

Within a day of the battle at Jessal, the Antinium armies were on the march again. The Black Tide rolled forth, but the defenders of the greatest continent in the world had not been idle in their preparations. Drake armies

marched against the Antinium, armed with the knowledge of their inability to swim and weakness against high-level magics and warriors.

However, the Antinium had not been idle either. The second battle against the Antinium took place between an army led by Wrymvr the Deathless and an army from Pallass. It was assumed that boxing in the Antinium and flooding their position would decimate their army, but the Drake High Command received the shock of a lifetime as new Antinium warriors overran their formations in minutes, slaying the [Mages] and throwing the army into disarray.

The Antinium fielded two new variants of their species in the Second Antinium War. Whether they always had such creatures or had somehow altered their own warriors with magic or alchemy is unknown and the subject of much speculation. However, the facts are clear: the Antinium had created a flying warrior capable of leaping across vast distances known as the Flying Antinium, and a stealthy infiltrator capable of camouflage and deadly surprise attacks known as the Silent Antinium.

These two new variants bridged the gap in the Antinium's formations, allowing them to swiftly flank their enemies and mount surprise attacks on vulnerable targets. The Drake armies which had relied on [Mages] for superiority fell backwards as the Antinium willingly sacrificed hundreds or thousands of their flying warriors to take out [Mages]. Meanwhile, the Silent Antinium infiltrated army camps and cities, slaying high-profile targets in the night.

The news of the new Antinium was devastating for morale across the Drake cities. And indeed, the fear the Silent Antinium created was such that many cities locked down their gates, refusing to open them for fear of infiltration. And yet the Silent Antinium crept behind their walls, locked gates or not, creating a wave of terror across the continent.

What ended up stopping the Silent Antinium in main was not any one military action, but rather, the existence of another, opposing force on the Drake side. The Assassin's Guild in the south of Izril took the existence of the Silent Antinium as a direct threat to their own way of life and put out a universal contract on every one of the Antinium's assassination insects. Thus, a quiet war began where [Assassin] dueled assassin-bug in the shadows.

This hidden conflict would become known as the War of Sighs, kept mainly out of the public view. The only evidence of the battles in shadow and darkness would be the corpses of the Silent Antinium and Drake [Assassins] appearing on doorsteps or in buildings, fallen where they had been slain. In Drake cities, inhabitants would wake up and discover dead Antinium gutted in the middle of a street or an [Assassin]'s head placed next to the bedsides of slaughtered Drake officials.

The most notable such event occurred at a meeting of Drake nobility in a private meeting room in the Walled City of Oteslia. The Lords and Ladies of the Wall conducted their meeting for ten minutes before an unpleasant odor led to them investigating the tables they were sitting at. They discovered the bodies of six Silent Antinium and four [Assassins] hidden under the tablecloths.

It is impossible to tell how many [Assassins] or Silent Antinium died in the conflict due to the elusive nature of both forces, and this writer has refrained from questioning the Assassin's Guild on the subject out of personal concern for his own safety. However, it is safe to say that the costs were tremendously high on both sides, such that the Assassin's Guild in the south of Izril has yet to recover, unlike the flourishing Human guilds to the north.

It is simply another example of Drake integrity one supposes, that fewer Drakes have the inclination to stab enemies in the back. An honest Drake

stabs from the front. But I digress...

The war between the Drakes and Antinium had taken a turn for the worse. While the Silent Antinium's assaults had been blunted, the armies led by Klbkch the Slayer, Xrn the Small Queen, and Wrymvr the Deathless seemed undefeatable by all but the most famous of the Drake [Generals].

Zel Shivertail managed to rout the Slayer's army in a pitched battle and the Small Queen's army found itself attacked by multiple armies, stalling her advance, but Wrymvr the Deathless rampaged unchecked behind Drake lines. This monstrous Prognugator of the Hives truly deserved the title of 'Deathless', because despite concerted efforts by multiple armies, the Prognugator refused to be slain and actively hunted down Drake commanders during battle.

The Antinium pushed forwards, again relentlessly overtaking city after city. It was as if the First Antinium War had returned with a vengeance as the Drakes found themselves on the back foot once more. And this time their Human allies were too preoccupied in the north to send assistance. For you see, the Necromancer had landed to the north, and his arrival had heralded a plague that swept the Human cities while his armies grew in number.

Az'kerash. The Necromancer. The bane of Terandria and now, Izril. His undead forces were never as numerous as the Antinium, but where his personal army went the Necromancer left only death in his wake. Where other [Necromancers] have raised armies of tens of thousands of zombies, ghouls, or skeletons, Az'kerash created far darker armies.

His forces consisted of Draugr, advanced and incredibly powerful zombies, wraiths, Crypt Lords, wights, and worst of all, Bone Giants. This foul horde of abominations moved ever southwards, heading towards Liscor while despoiling Human lands on the way.

And for what purpose? For what reason did he turn his gaze so suddenly to Izril? This befuddled writer has no notion, dear readers. Perhaps the Necromancer sensed the confusion caused by the Antinium, or had grown bored of Terandria. Then again, what rational thought can be ascribed to such a horror? It is enough to say he went south, and his undead armies distracted the Humans in the Drakes' darkest hour.

“Dead gods, this [Writer] really does drone on a lot. Doesn't he realize how biased he is? It's not as if the Humans had a fun time fighting all those undead, you know.”

Ceria complained out loud and Pisces broke off from reading the very battered book in his hands. Pisces sniffed in annoyance as he looked up from reading and glanced about the inn.

“I personally find it incredible how dismissive he seems to be of the Necromancer's true intentions. Then again, I shouldn't be surprised; Krsysl Wordsmith's works have never been—how shall I put it?—particularly innovative. The best he can do is parrot other authors' analyses and commentary.”

He sniffed again, but his audience seemed disinclined to support his opinion. Mrsha scratched at one ear as Lyonette held her on her lap. Jelaqua looked up from her cup, eyebrows raised, and Moore and Seborn looked up from their game of cards.

The inn wasn't that full this late at night. Drassi and Lyonette were manning the inn, but their own guests were the Horns of Hammerad, the Halfseekers, Mrsha, and the five Redfang Warriors who were sitting at a distant table, jabbering to themselves. They had been having a rather idle night with Erin gone, until Pisces had produced the book and begun reading from it.

Since he was a good reader no one had minded—until now. Ceria wondered if she'd made a mistake in interrupting. Pisces *loved* to poke holes in other people's statements and he wouldn't shut up if he thought someone was wrong.

The half-Elf sighed as she sat at the table with Pisces, Ksmvr, and Yvlon. She eyed the book in Pisces' hands and raised her eyebrow at the [Necromancer] she thought of as a friend.

"If you don't like him so much, why do you have a copy of his book, Pisces? And why do you insist on reading it aloud?"

"It is impossible to point out the flaws in his arguments without first hearing them. Besides which, I am offended by the lack of knowledge in this room! Ksmvr has never heard a history of the Antinium Wars, young Mrsha and Miss Lyonette have received only the scantest of summaries, and as for Yvlon and Miss Drassi—"

"I know the history of the Second Antinium War you jerk!"

Drassi called out from across the room. She propped her hands on her hips and glared at Pisces.

"Every Drake knows the history! And I bet Miss Yvlon knows her history too!"

"I did study the war, Pisces."

Yvlon raised her eyebrows at Pisces. He curled his lip.

"Ah, education. And did you receive your wonderful education from this book, Miss Drassi, Miss Byres?"

The two young women hesitated. Pisces nodded.

"I thought so. How unfortunate. This 'historical narrative' is riddled with flaws. Oh I suppose as a form of propaganda it has some merit, but as

an accurate insight into the minds of those who fought in the war? Hardly.”

“If you’re so smart, you tell us what the Necromancer was thinking. You like dead things. Why’d Az’kerash invade Izril all of a sudden, then? And don’t tell me ‘it’s obvious,’ because that means you don’t actually know.”

Ceria growled at Pisces. She looked over at Mrsha; the Gnoll was yawning widely, not particularly interested in the debate. Pisces noticed the look and frowned. He eyed Mrsha and then twirled his fingers.

A wind blew through the inn, making everyone look up. Ceria glanced towards the windows, and door, but they were closed. Pisces smiled as the wind blew at his robes, and then flicked his hands.

“You want a story based in facts, Springwalker? Very well, I suppose I can oblige you.”

“I never said—”

Too late. The lights in the room dimmed. Ceria looked around as the light from the fireplace seemed to grow behind Pisces and his shadow grew large on the wall. Mrsha looked up as Pisces snapped his fingers and sparks erupted in the air around him. Yvlon shot back from the table, swearing, and Ksmvr ducked. Ceria just batted at a flurry of glowing embers that flew past her.

“Stop the illusions, Pisces.”

He grinned at her, the air around him aglow with lights.

“Atmosphere is important, Ceria. Besides, if I am to tell a story, I might as well do it justice. Now...”

He coughed and his voice grew deeper, more resonant. Pisces turned his seat so he was facing Mrsha and the Redfang Warriors, all of whom stared

at him with sudden interest. He gestured dramatically and the shadows on the wall grew behind him as he spoke.

“Az’kerash. The Necromancer. You want to know his true intentions? Why he truly came to Izril? Well then, understand he was no mere [Necromancer]. He was once an Archmage of Wistram, acknowledged universally as one of the greatest magic users of all time. And though he was cast out and his name besmirched, his power in undeath was unmatched.”

“We know that. Get to the point.”

Pisces glared at Ceria, but went on, his shadows transforming into a vast and hooded figure behind him. Mrsha stared at it with wide eyes as Lyonette hugged her reassuringly, seeing lurching and shambling forms moving across the walls. Pisces’ voice was a low echo throughout the room.

“While the Antinium fought, the Necromancer sowed chaos among the Human cities in the north. He marched south, his small army growing with each day from the dead. However, his target was never any lone Human city—no. He travelled south, towards the Drake lands with a purpose. Not simply to destroy.”

“Oh really? You’re going to tell us he had a plan? Did it involve getting himself killed?”

Ceria smirked at Pisces, making him stop and frown at her again. She smiled, and then stopped when she saw Ksmvr putting a finger in front of his mouth. She looked around and realized she was the only one not taking Pisces seriously.

“Go on. What did the Necromancer want if he didn’t want to just kill people? Did he want something the Drakes had?”

Jelaqua leaned over her table, looking casually interested. Across the room, the Goblins were pointing at the shadow illusions Pisces had conjured and trying to make their own with their hands.

He grinned, and the room went dark except for flickering lights around his face. Mrsha squeaked. Ceria sighed.

“The Necromancer? He desired the treasures of the Walled Cities, of course. Not what was contained in the cities themselves though. Oh no. What he wanted was the secrets of the walls themselves.”

“Hey Pisces? I know you’re being dramatic, but I can’t see, and I’m trying to clean up the plates. Can you make it a bit brighter?”

Drassi interrupted, waving her claw in the air. The room grew a bit lighter and Pisces looked put out. He cleared his throat meaningfully as the Drake walked around the room, gathering plates.

“*As I was saying*—the Walled Cities contain a powerful secret. Consider them, for a moment. The famous Drake cities whose fortifications are practically impregnable against attack. Constructed in the age of Dragons, a bastion for Drake kind. Why is it that no other Walled Cities were ever made in the millennia since? Were they truly the product of great magics or is there another secret to their construction? The answer is simple: there is a secret, and it is one that is hidden in plain sight in the history books. Although perhaps only a [Necromancer] would be able to see it.”

“Oh really? You know the secret of how the Walled Cities were built? Well color me impr—”

Ceria felt something wet splat into the side of her face and yelped, breaking off from her heckling. She saw Mrsha glaring at her, a paw full of tonight’s dinner—spaghetti and meatballs. She’d hit Ceria with a meatball.

“Mrsha! Stop that!”

Lyonette scolded the Gnoll as Ceria ate the meatball, resigned to silence. Pisces smirked victoriously and went on. Against the wall, armies of shadowy undead marched, pursuing fleeing Humans.

“Oh yes. The secret is out there. But as I say, hidden. Let us look at the facts: the last Walled City was built right as the age of Dragons ended. As the Dragons went into hiding and their species as a whole dwindled in number. The Walled Cities were meant to defend from Dragons and while many have fallen over the thousands of years that have passed, those that still stand have the same strength as they did in the days of yore. What magics could last so long? No—what materials could hold such enchantments without waning in power? Stone is weak compared to the onslaught of years. But what if there was another ingredient, another part of the walls that gave them their mythical strength? That is what Az’kerash discovered, what he desired above all else.”

“This is better than one of those street performances in the big cities.”

Jelaqua whispered to her teammates as everyone leaned forwards. Ksmvr spoke, his voice quivering with anticipation.

“What is this secret, Comrade Pisces? Tell us.”

Ceria resolved to kick Pisces if he didn’t have a good answer. The [Necromancer] looked around, his eyes glinting in the fire’s light.

“Why, Dragon bones of course. The Walled Cities are made with the strength of Dragons. The Drakes took the skeletons of their ancestors and placed them in the walls. That is why the Walled Cities are unique, why they are so powerful. And it is why the Necromancer marched south.”

At Pisces’ words, there was a gasp across the inn. Ceria froze, foot poised to kick. And then everyone jumped as they heard a *crash* of breaking pottery. Drassi had dropped the stack of plates she’d been carrying. She

stared at Pisces, ignoring Lyonette as the young woman leapt to her feet to make sure Drassi wasn't hurt.

“Are you serious, Pisces? *Dragon* bones?”

Pisces nodded, smiling in satisfaction as everyone gaped at him. He raised a finger, and the broken pieces of the plates danced into the air, neatly piling themselves up on a table.

“Of course I'm certain, Springwalker. I can't verify the facts myself, as the Walled Cities' secrets are jealously guarded, but I imagine the Lords and Ladies of the Wall know the truth. I wonder how those arrogant Drakes reconcile that fact? Perhaps they take comfort knowing they hide behind the bones of their ancient parents. Whatever the case...Az'kerash must have known, and so he marched his armies ever southwards, intending to form an army capable of razing a Walled City for himself.”

“But he failed. That's the point, isn't it? He never got past Liscor.”

Yvlon stared hard at Pisces, clenching her fists gently and rubbing at her metallic arms. Pisces nodded.

“Naturally, the Necromancer's plans failed. His armies did indeed cross past Liscor while he besieged the city, and caused much damage to Drake lands, but he failed to achieve his goals because he failed to take into account the other factor in the war.”

Ceria looked around.

“The Goblins?”

Pisces grinned, and the shifting mass of shadows on the wall behind him turned into the silhouette of a huge Goblin with a crown. The Redfang Warriors looked around, suddenly the focus of the room. Pisces opened the book he was reading.

“Indeed. The Goblins. Or more accurately, the Goblin King.”

Antinium in the south. The Necromancer to the north. It seemed like Izril was in chaos, but there was no despair in the tails of the Drakes as they fought back against the hated Antinium. The war was winnable, and indeed, if the Humans could muster some backbone, the Antinium could be defeated again. That was the prevailing mood. At least, until the Goblin King arrived.

Velan the Kind had conducted a bloody war in Baleros, but it has to be said that he refrained from leading his armies deep into the jungles of that continent. Rather, he consolidated his forces, calling mighty Goblin Lords and Goblin Chieftains to his cause, swelling his army. He must have known the futility of any advance—the Four Great Companies of Baleros were all united against him, and a vast host had been formed to destroy him. But before the Balerosian forces could clash with the Goblin King, his entire army vanished into the sea.

That was the Goblin King’s master plan. That was why he had seized so many port cities—not to create a foothold, but to flee across the sea, to an easier target! And the naïve commanders of Baleros, the much-vaunted mercenary companies, had given him the time to create enough ships for his armies in their cautious advance.

Yes, this historian will say it if no one else will! If the forces of Baleros hadn’t dragged their feet so, the Goblin King might have been eliminated before he could attack Izril! For that was exactly where his vast armada sailed.

The Goblin King's armies crossed the oceans from Baleros, winning two notable battles at sea. The first, against a fleet of Minotaurs sent from their isles and the second at Wistram. The overconfident Minotaurs had expected to destroy the Goblin King, but their ships were no match for his Goblin Lords and the Goblin King himself.

It must be noted that the Goblin Lords each possessed a might on par with any Named Adventurer, and the Goblin King himself was reckoned a match for all but the strongest warriors in the world. Speculation has been rife as to what would have been the outcome if a famed warrior such as Mars the Illusionist had met him in battle. Alas, the outcome of such a duel will never be known, especially because the Goblin King's armies prevented any surgical strikes against the Goblin King or his lords.

Nine Goblin Lords sailed with the Goblin King, each of different ability. Some were infamous for their might, such as Greydath of Blades or the Goblin King's right hand, the Goblin Lord [Shaman] known as Tallis the Stormbreaker. Others were less distinguished, but the true terror of their abilities was displayed in the second battle as a force from Wistram sought to interrupt the Goblin King's crossing.

The Archmage Balkizat sailed against the Goblin King's army himself with a small army of [Mages], determined to sink the Goblin King at sea where his army was weakest. There he dueled Tallis the Stormbreaker in a magical battle that lasted for nine hours. On the ninth hour, Balkizat was slain by the Goblin King's [Shaman] and the forces of Wistram retreated, hiding behind their magical walls until the Goblins had passed.

The defeat of an Archmage of Wistram marked a turning point in the perceived Goblin King's threat worldwide. Other nations that had viewed themselves as removed from the struggle began to respond to requests for military assistance. But that would come too late for Izril. The Goblin King landed with the bulk of his forces in Cape Heathshell on the northwestern

edge of Izril. From there he began invading the Human lands with a fury that exceeded that of the Antinium and Necromancer alike.

Faced with this new and dismaying threat, the Humans finally roused themselves to definite action. Unfortunately, hubris still gripped their addled minds, which led to the disastrous decision by two of the Five Families to send an army against the Goblin King, as if he could be swept away so easily. A force of about a hundred thousand [Knights] and [Lancers] was formed and led by Fulviolo El and the famed twins, Petria and Ulva Terland.

This army met the Goblin King's vanguard in a pitched battle three days after his forces landed. By all accounts, within ten minutes the Goblin King's soldiers had routed the Human army and the Goblin King personally beheaded Fulviolo and Petria, while Ulva Terland escaped with her life. With a single stroke he broke the backs of two of the Five Families and obliterated their personal armies so thoroughly that less than a hundred survivors escaped the battle.

Despair had come for the Humans, and it was in the shape of Goblins, not the Necromancer's undead or the Antinium. The Goblin King's armies rolled over all Human opposition, pushing towards what many considered the Humans' capital, First Landing, their oldest and grandest city on the continent.

Obviously, oldest and grandest is a relative term, since the Walled Cities predate the construction of First Landing by at least six thousand years, but it was the Humans' only claim to glory, and the metaphorical heart of their people. If the capital city of humanity on Izril fell, there would be no rallying point for the Humans.

Thus, the Five Families and every noble house within six hundred miles of the city gathered their forces for a desperate stand at the city walls. Eight Goblin Lords besieged the city for three weeks, leading charges that

resulted in bloodbaths for both sides. But they were unable to take the city by sheer force of arms. At least, in the beginning.

The Five Families, the legendary founding houses that first invaded Izril from Terandria millennia ago, are known to be fractious and distrustful of one another. However, as the Goblin King's armies assailed the walls of their city and his forces ravaged their homes, the banners of all five families were raised in unison for the first time in over a thousand years.

Each of the five houses opened their garrisons and sent their scions to the front. Of their number, Lady Magnolia Reinhart and Lord Tyrion Veltras were most notable for their accomplishments during the war. It was Lord Tyrion who took command of the defense of the city, establishing his prowess as a military leader while Lady Magnolia marshaled the rest of the land's nobility in defense of their home. And it was she who implemented a tactic born of sheer desperation as the Goblin King's forces began to overwhelm the city's defenders.

While every [Lord] had been called into military service at the start of the conflict with the Goblin King, the [Ladies] of the realm had refrained from taking part in the fighting, due to some Human notion of sentimentality. However, the desperation of the Human defenders finally spurred the female nobility to act. Two weeks into the slaughter, Magnolia Reinhart and every [Lady] in the city appeared on the front lines and lent their Skills during the battles against the Goblin King.

It is at this point that some explanations are required for readers unfamiliar with Human culture. It is a peculiarity of Humans that their female population, especially their nobility, refuses to take part in most battles unless specifically trained in combat. The idea of gender segregation is, of course, completely foreign to Drakes, Gnolls and most other species, but it remains a romanticized Human notion. And indeed, up

until this point, although every [Lord] had taken part in the fighting, no [Lady] had entered battle in person.

Now however, the [Ladies] appeared en masse, going into combat with their personal escorts and lending their Skills to the Human warriors. Most [Ladies] possessed only the lowest-level of combat Skills, but as any [Tactician] worth their salt will note, the heat of combat rapidly increases one's level and grants combat-based Skills. Thus, although weak, the Skills of hundreds of [Ladies] were multiplied across the battlefield, allowing the Humans to push back the surprised Goblins. It must also be said that the psychological impact of seeing their female nobility willing to risk their lives in battle strengthened the Human soldiers' resolve, adding to their sudden strategic advantage.

This daring tactic surprised the Goblin King, as did the unusual skill and courage of the Human defenders, a rarity in their species as a whole. He quickly realized the nature of the Humans' comeback however, and enacted a plan of his own to destroy the Humans' vestiges of hope. The Goblin King ordered his vassals to target the relatively undefended [Ladies] as they hid behind the front lines. And there began the slaughter known to the world as the Sacrifice of Roses.

The Goblin Lords pinpointed the ranks of the [Ladies], leading charges in person to slaughter the helpless nobility where they stood. The defining aspect of the battle, however, was that the Humans, uncharacteristically, refused to run when their death was imminent. Rather than flee and break the battle lines, they fought to the last woman, holding their ground long enough for their soldiers to enact blood vengeance on the Goblins who had pushed so far into their lines. One of the lesser Goblin Lords, Murmar, was confirmed to have been slain as a result of these defensive actions. However, the cost came at the near-total annihilation of the [Ladies] targeted.

This valiant defense of their home at the cost of their own lives became a defining moment in the Human resistance against the Goblin King, an icon that demonstrated the courage of Izril even in the face of overwhelming odds. The Sacrifice of Roses became a rallying cry across Izril and has been lauded to this day as a defining moment of courage.

Perhaps too much so. If this humble [Writer] may be so bold as to interject his own opinion at this point, much has been made of the sacrifices of the Human nobility of Izril during the Second Antinium War. However, I would characterize their sacrifice as valorous, but not above that of any Drake or indeed, Human [Soldier]. Accounts of Ladies of the Wall participating and falling in battle are verified and recorded—why should Humans take more credit for what was, in truth, a rather costly and ineffective strategy employed in a single series of battles?

Lest I remind you dear readers, the Human [Ladies] of Izril only took to the front lines as a last stand. Is their singular moment of sacrifice worth more than any bereaved Drake family mourning the loss of a [Soldier]? It was an acceptable measure taken in a desperate situation, not, I feel, a moment of true heroism as has been claimed by others.

“Stop reading that.”

A hand reached down and covered the book in front of Lady Bethal. She looked up, surprised, as her husband, the [Chevalier] Thomast, frowned at her. She sat up in bed, looking around the tent they were sharing in the army’s campgrounds outside of Invrissil. The two had come to the battlefield to fight against the Goblin Lord’s army. Lady Bethal had declined Magnolia Reinhart’s offer of hospitality so she could stay with her husband on the night before the battle.

She had been reading the history of the second Antinium wars in a delicately-bound pink book in the bed her [Knights] had carried ten miles to

the campsite. Now she closed it, her hands trembling slightly as Thomast looked at her.

“I was just reading, Thomast. Is that a crime?”

Her eyes sparkled with her infamous temper. Thomast, renowned for his silence and lack of temper in contrast to his wife’s moods, simply shook his head.

“Not a crime. But you know it’s not true.”

“It’s what’s written, isn’t it? That Drake [Writer] thinks we Human [Ladies] are cowards. And perhaps we are? Isn’t that why you’re sending me away, rather than letting me watch the battle?”

“You would not watch if I was in danger. You would try to save me and we might both perish. I can’t allow that.”

“Allow? I’m your *wife*.”

Bethal’s eyes widened and her nostrils flared. She sat up in her bed and Thomast carefully avoided meeting her eyes, as if she were a wild animal. He looked at her hands instead. They were shaking ever so slightly as they rested on the book.

“You are my wife. And this is a war. General Shivertail is commanding—he can’t have unpredictable elements interfering with his strategy.”

“I can take orders! I *have* fought in a war before, Thomast.”

“I know. And I know you can fight. But not this time. Stop reading about the past, please.”

He reached for the book. Bethal clutched it to her chest. She was breathing faster now, her voice rising in agitation.

“Why can’t I read, Thomast?”

“Because it’s not true.”

“It’s what’s written!”

“And it is not true. Bethal—”

“We *fought*, Thomast! All of us! We fought and we died and this arrogant worm of a Drake has the *nerve* to question our bravery! As if we didn’t know our soldiers were dying? But we still died, and for what? If this is how history remembers us, wouldn’t it have been better to run? To be remembered as cowards, but be alive? Rather than—than *this*?”

She hurled the book across the tent. Thomast sighed and stroked at his mustache.

“It’s not true. You know that. I know that.”

“And what about everyone else? What about children, what about people who read this book and don’t know the truth? How can he write this? How can—”

Her husband was silent, gently sitting still as Bethal shouted. She wanted him to yell back, but found it was hard to look at him. Her vision was—swimming.

Bethal reached up and found her eyes were full of tears. She wiped them away almost absentmindedly at first. But the tears kept coming. She tried to keep her voice steady, but it began to break.

“It’s—we knew what would happen, Thomast. Magnolia told us. She said—we all agreed. No quarter. No mercy. But we still did it. We—we—”

“I know. Love, I know.”

Thomast reached out and held Bethal. Her shoulders began to shake. She kept talking, stumbling, choking, but forcing the words out.

“I remember the banners. There were so many to begin with. But each time the Goblin King charged—there were so many Goblins. Each time he charged the banners disappeared. More and more of them. Just—missing. I was separated from the others in the fighting. And when the Goblin King retreated I looked for Mother, but she was gone. So were Maisy and Lady Alvita and Eruvie—all gone. Father was gone and then the horns blew again and he charged and—so many. They were gone, Thomast. All gone.”

She began to weep. Thomast held Bethal, hugging her tightly. She whispered, tears streaming down her face.

“We held the line. None of us ran, not even when the Goblin Lords appeared. Even when they cut us down. I still dream of that night. I know it shouldn’t matter, but when I read this—”

“It is not true.”

Thomast said it fiercely. Bethal clung to him.

“Say it again. Louder, please.”

“It is not true!”

The [Chevalier]’s voice raised, and Bethal lowered her head. Time passed slowly, and her shaking stopped. Thomast offered her a handkerchief to wipe her face and blow her nose. Bethal did so, and then turned to Thomast with the smallest of smiles.

“Do you know how I first heard of you, Thomast? It was before we met at the ball at Magnolia’s estate. I must confess I had planned running into you. Although I had not planned to actually run *into* you, much less dirty your clothes. I was determined to meet you. You see, I had read the open letter you had sent to this Drake [Historian].”

“Oh?”

Thomast knew what Lady Bethal was referring to, but he let her tell her story, stroking her hands. Bethal smiled up at him.

“I still remember what you wrote. Do you? I’ll repeat it. I memorized it by heart.”

“Tell me. What did I write?”

“You wrote to that horrible Drake. That Wordsmith. You said—oh, how did it begin? Oh yes, *Dear Sir*.”

Dear Sir,

I am writing to you in regards to the popular book you recently published, entitled The Second Antinium Wars, a History. I take issue with several passages within your historical narrative, most notably the paragraphs where you question the sacrifice of the [Ladies] of Izril during the Sacrifice of Roses.

I find it incredible that you would attack the deceased, much less from the safety of your quill, far from any actual danger. It appears that it is easy for you and others who enjoy the concept of peace to criticize those who gave their lives in battle, knowing full well the odds against them. I hope you have a tenth of the courage it takes to stand your ground wearing nothing but a dress and holding a dagger against an oncoming Goblin army.

I trust you will retract your comments and issue a public apology swiftly as to avoid further disgracing this historical account. Your attack on the courage of the fallen is a disgrace to your class and to the truth. Species matters not. The honor and bravery displayed by Drakes, Humans, Gnolls, and every other species during the war should not be called into question,

much less by someone who never fought in either war. I was there and I will never forget their sacrifice.

Sincerely,

Thomast Veniral, [Fencer]

“I fell in love with you just a bit after reading that.”

“Mm. I regret writing that. I was young and it only put his back up. I was challenged to eight duels within the week.”

“So?”

Bethal gripped Thomast’s hands fiercely, her eyes blazing.

“You were *right!* And that Drake will never admit it, but you spoke the truth. You were right, Thomast. Never regret telling the truth. And it was the truth. We knew what we were doing. We—”

Her voice broke again. And again Thomast held her. This time he kissed her gently on each cheek and then on her lips. Bethal’s voice trembled.

“That night the roses fought and fell. But we never ran. We marched on, through the rain and mud and death. So many of us. So few afterwards. And when the Goblin King charged we blazed and died like fireflies in the night. But we stopped him.”

“You did.”

Thomast embraced his wife. She sobbed into his vest.

“Thomast? Kiss me please.”

He did. The book lay on the floor, forgotten. But the pages went on, flawed fiction mixing with grains of truth to tell a story. Such was history.

Whatever the case, the defense of First Landing and the subsequent Sacrifice of Roses blunted the Goblin King's attacks. The loss of the first of the Goblin Lords shook the Goblin King and he withdrew his forces after it became clear the Humans were too well-entrenched to uproot without sacrificing part of his army. Instead, the Goblin King ordered his Lords to conduct a campaign of fire on the landscape, razing farmlands and smaller targets while he maintained the siege, intending to starve the Humans out.

The advance of the Goblins had stalled for the first time, a cause for celebration perhaps. But the cost was passing high. In cases where Goblins succeeded in overrunning or bypassing the Human lines and engaging the personal retinues led by said [Ladies], casualties were absolute. Over 60% of the [Ladies] who took to the front lines perished in battle along with their escorts.

Their deaths, along with their [Lord] counterparts, has led to a vacuum in the ranks of the landowning classes in the Human lands that has persisted to this day. Conversely, however, those [Lords] and [Ladies] who did survive the Second Antinium War all obtained high levels and absorbed vast tracts of land into their estates.

And of course, the battle for First Landing was not yet over. The Human defenders might have faced months of deprivation and slowly dwindling food supplies under the siege warfare, but for an unexpected attack on the Goblin King's armies from the Reinhart estate.

Magnolia Reinhart, one of the leading figures of the First Antinium War, led a counterattack from her estate on the Goblin King's forces. Despite having committed virtually all of her family's soldiers to the defense of First Landing, she appeared two weeks after the Sacrifice of Roses with another army a hundred thousand strong.

To the amazement of all, she drove the Goblin King's army back with a magical army of constructs. She had summoned this vast force with the use

of an artifact known as the Crown of Flowers. This artifact is known as one of the great treasures of the Humans of Izril, and is in fact rumored to be the very same artifact used to conquer the Drake cities when the invasion of the continent first took place thousands of years ago.

Not much is known about the Crown of Flowers, as its powers are a well-guarded secret. Indeed, they are considered so potent that Magnolia Reinhart was forced to negotiate with the Assassin's Guild to ensure her life and the artifact would not be targeted for the duration of the war. This was the first incident where she struck a deal with the Assassin's Guild, but it would lead to her widespread employment of [Assassins] throughout the years following the Second Antinium War. But that is beside the point.

It is not clear why Magnolia Reinhart did not employ the Crown of Flowers as soon as the Goblin King's forces reached Izril, but prominent [Mages] speculate that she may have in fact done so. The army summoned by the Crown of Flowers was comprised of powerful plant-based constructs which grew in power the longer they existed, 'blooming' into their full power over time. It may be that it was only after weeks had passed that the Crown of Flowers had been able to summon the army at this desperate hour.

Whatever the case, the interlude in the fighting had given the crown's powers time enough to work. The army of constructs summoned by the Crown of Flowers grew out of the ground and assembled around the Reinhart estate near First Landing and marched south. They attacked the surprised Goblin King's army and, in tandem with the Human defenders, forced him to retreat.

This unexpected victory forced the Goblins back and earned Lady Magnolia Reinhart the title of 'The Deadly Flower Blooming in the North'. She had shown the Goblin King her thorns and his armies withdrew, giving the Humans some breathing room, however small.

The sudden retreat by the Goblin forces may have been due to the Goblin King's absence from the battlefield at that time. Confident in the abilities of his Goblin Lords to maintain the siege, he had vanished from the battlefields. Reportedly, the Goblin King had rapidly moved south with a small force, entering the High Passes. There he vanished for eight days.

What he did during that time is largely unknown, but it is speculated he personally cut a path through the treacherous High Passes, fighting the myriad monsters that formed their lairs in that place. And after eight days had passed, the Goblin King appeared south of the High Passes. He had opened up a gateway between north and south Izril, bypassing the defenses of Liscor entirely. Thus, the Goblins were now able to reinforce their armies on both sides, giving them another strategic advantage over the separated Drake and Human forces.

A note at this point. While I have written exclusively about Drakes and Humans, it would be wrong to write further without touching upon the contributions, or rather, lack thereof by the Gnoll species during this time. The Gnoll tribes did indeed take part in resisting the Antinium advance and fought against the Goblin King in some numbers, but their presence was mostly seen in a defensive role, as with the First Antinium War.

The Gnoll tribes' insular and cowardly attitude towards battle may have been seen most disgracefully in regards to the Necromancer, however. The Gnoll species as a whole has more reason than most to hate his existence—after all, the Necromancer earned his name over a century ago when he slew the beloved Chieftain of the Gnolls who some had labeled the first 'King of Gnolls'. The Necromancer killed the Gnoll Chieftain Kerash and was thus dubbed Az'kerash, or 'Slayer of Kerash' by the Gnolls.

And yet, as his armies travelled south, the Necromancer faced little opposition from the Gnolls, who seemed more fearful of his advance than enraged. The Gnoll tribes contributed little to the defense of the land, and

indeed, are conspicuously absent in most major battles of the Second Antinium War.

“We fought! What nonsense is this?”

Krshia’s paw slapped the book’s pages. The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] growled out loud and snarled at the text as she got up and paced around her apartment.

“We *fought!* We did! Not all tribes, but did all Drakes fight? No! My tribe fought, and countless others! We did not fear the Necromancer, no! How dare this Drake write otherwise? He calls himself a historian? I have seen more accurate histories written on shopping lists!”

She hurled the book to the ground and stomped on it before picking it up and checking it for damage.

“Hrr. I can still sell this, though. Perhaps I can even sell it for more if I rip out these pages. They would make good toilet paper, no?”

Grudgingly, Krshia flicked the book open and kept reading, although her tail was angrily thrashing back and forth.

Regardless, the Necromancer advanced south, largely undeterred by the war going on between Goblins and Humans. To my understanding he only clashed with the Goblin King’s forces once, and the battle ended as a stalemate between Az’kerash and the Goblin King. It appears both forces largely ignored each other after that, and the Necromancer exploited the fractured militaries of both Humans and Drakes by marching his army to Liscor unimpeded.

It was there the Necromancer’s armies besieged the Drake city and cut the continent in two. The Drakes could not assist the Humans and vice

versa. Perhaps this was to aid the Goblin King after all, because it meant neither side could assist one another while the Goblins enjoyed the use of the High Passes. And meanwhile, the Necromancer's forces spread out, heading south of the Blood Fields and harvesting more bodies for his army.

The siege of Liscor is of course a famous and heroic tale of defiance by the courageous Drake defenders and I fear I can do it little justice with only a few pages of writing. However, let us begin by saying that the Liscorian army had withdrawn around their city in advance of the Necromancer's assaults, and held the walls of their city as the Necromancer concentrated the bulk of his forces in an attempt to bring it down.

Liscor had never fallen to siege since its creation as a city-state. The natural geography of the city combined with their advanced walls and powerful army meant that they were able to repel most assaults with ease. However, the Necromancer had brought armies of powerful undead and the aforementioned Bone Giants to assault Liscor's walls. The Liscorian army was forced to fight the undead on the walls and slew the giants only at great cost. And though the Necromancer's giants failed to break Liscor's walls, they had done such terrible damage that there was no hope of Liscor repelling the undead alone.

A truly grueling siege of Liscor began, as the Necromancer inflicted plagues on the city's inhabitants, launched rotting corpses over the walls, and personally unleashed his magics on the city's defenders. It was an attack that would have felled a lesser city, much less a Human one, in a single day. And yet, Liscor held on. Against all odds, they endured first one week, then two, and then four weeks against the Necromancer's onslaught. Every citizen fought to defend the city, hoping against hope for relief.

And it came from none other than Zel Shivertail, the Tidebreaker himself. The Drake [General] had heard of Liscor's plight and abandoned his battles against the Antinium to march north. He, the former student and

friend of General Sserys of Liscor, would not abandon Sserys' people in their hour of need. Shivertail did not march alone either; three other Drake [Generals] joined him with their armies, and they cut a path to the Necromancer and assaulted his army at Liscor.

This climactic battle would be known as one of the most famous battles of the Second Antinium War. It began as Zel Shivertail's forces attacked the Necromancer's entrenched army around the city. Accounts of the battle have been verified and multiple perspectives have been recorded. To summarize the tragic opening to the battle, I will be brief.

On the first day, Az'kerash slew [General] Hekiss. On the second, [General] Vusso fell and two hours later, [General] Misa. Only Zel Shivertail remained as the Necromancer's forces threatened to overwhelm both the city of Liscor and the attacking army.

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S02 – The Antinium Wars (Pt.4)

Dear readers, it is not in my nature to exaggerate or lie. I, Krsysl Wordsmith, attempt to tell you the most unbiased of accounts possible. But I cannot suppress my patriotic pride for my people. And the following account of the Siege of Liscor by the Necromancer, Az'kerash, is almost impossible to tell without appreciating the grave odds of the struggle, the desperation, and above all, the hope and courage exhibited by the brave Drakes of Liscor and the hero Zel Shivertail himself.

Consider it, dear readers. Liscor imperiled once more and this time the Necromancer unleashing his undead hordes on the gateway to the southern continent, attempting to succeed where the Antinium had failed nearly a decade ago. And oh, but he was succeeding. Liscor's defenses had been improved since the last war, their walls built higher and spelled with new enchantments. But the Necromancer had brought an army capable of destroying all but a Walled City, and with every fallen soldier his forces grew.

And what was the Drake High Command doing? Nothing! They were fighting the Antinium on every front and now facing a Goblin King's invasion as well. Who could they send? Who could rally an army strong enough to destroy the Necromancer and break his siege?

The Tidebreaker would. For his late comrade General Sserys, to save his friend's beloved city, he gathered three other Drake armies, each led by a [General] of the Drake cities. I urge you to imagine it. Four [Generals] marched on the Necromancer. And each one increased the strength of the combined army they led until it was unstoppable.

This technique of ‘stacking’ high-level commanders and leaders has been used to great effect across the world; indeed, in the last Izril-Terandrian war, the Human armies were pathetically crushed by superior Drake forces who sent in multiple [Commander] classes into each battle, allowing them to utilize Skill-based tactics and enhance their army’s fighting quality far beyond the Terandrian armies. (Of course, the individual ability of each Drake soldier over the Human soldiers may have also played a part in such victories.)

Zel Shivertail had created a force capable of wiping out the Necromancer despite his great power. Four [Generals] should have broken the back of his army within a day. But instead the Necromancer slew General Hekiss, Vusso, and then Misa with his fell magics, turning the tide of battle in an instant.

How? How could he slay the pride of the Drakes with such contemptuous ease? It seems that the Drakes, the Humans, and perhaps even the Goblin Lord and Antinium underestimated him. The Necromancer was no mere distraction from the war—he was a side unto himself! He had the magical prowess to destroy enemy armies and [Generals] from afar; shielded by his undead he could fight at his leisure, overrunning cities with ease.

He destroyed every army that he encountered, save for the Goblin King’s. Even an Antinium army sent north was obliterated, although not made into undead. It appears even the Necromancer has standards for his undead—or that the Antinium made for poor corpses.

Regardless, the hope of salvation for Liscor had turned into a nightmarish situation as the Drake army sent to liberate the city found itself on the brink of being wiped out. And perhaps they would have been. The Necromancer ordered his undead to encircle the army and Liscor, hoping to swell his deathless horde further. But he failed to destroy the Drake army on

the third day, and the fourth, and every day after that. For one simple reason:

He could not kill the Tidebreaker.

Not by magic, not by overwhelming numbers or ambush! General Zel Shivertail remained on the battlefield despite Az'kerash's repeated assaults on him day after day. The famed [General of the Line] refused to retreat, and it was his rallying presence and Skills that kept the Drake armies and the valiant defenders of Liscor from folding under the Necromancer's devastating attacks.

And yet, dear readers, Zel Shivertail's weakness became apparent as he failed to dispatch the Necromancer despite charging into enemy lines again and again. The Tidebreaker is known to be the best defensive [General] in Liscor, and indeed, perhaps the world.

Unlike the late General Sserys, who was known for his offensive strategies, Zel Shivertail's Skills mainly revolve around defensive formations and holding the line, despite his exceptional personal combat prowess. Thus, he was unable to launch a decisive strike and corner the Necromancer—when he would charge Az'kerash's position, the Necromancer would screen himself with his undead troops or disappear.

And so the battle became a deadly stalemate, as both armies refused to retreat. So long as the Necromancer lived, the undead would continue rising, empowered by their dark master. And so long as Zel Shivertail refused to fall, the Drakes fought on. And yet, and yet dear reader, the undead began to triumph.

For every Drake that fell at Liscor, an undead zombie or ghoul would rise in its place. And Az'kerash's own magical mastery allowed him to create a number of greater undead each day. Meanwhile, the people of Liscor and Zel Shivertail's own army were finite in number. The siege wore

on as Zel Shivertail requested urgent reinforcements to defeat the Necromancer. Alas, the Drake High Command was once again unable to act.

The Antinium were sweeping down from their Hives, and worse, the Goblin King's armies had also begun to march. Unlike the Human campaign in the north, Velan the Kind left the strategy in the south to only one of his Goblin Lords, if the mightiest of them.

Tallis the Stormbreaker.

The great [Shaman] of the Goblin armies came late to the war between the Antinium and Drakes. He began by sacking port cities along the western coast, and then slowly moved inland. The Drake armies were no match for his overwhelming magical might, and he routed armies with contemptuous ease. Drakes across the continent despaired hearing of Tallis Stormbreaker's advance, because the Antinium were already besieging Pallass and Zeres, threatening to once again cut the continent in two.

But here history takes a fortunate turn. Because as luck would have it, the Goblin Lord's advance sent him perilously close to an Antinium Hive. And the thoughtless, foolish Antinium saw his armies not as a potential ally, but simply as another threat. They sent Xrn, the Small Queen, to deal with Tallis Stormbreaker as they had every other army. And here the Antinium suffered their first great defeat of the war. The Stormbreaker annihilated the Antinium army with a single spell within ten minutes of the Antinium charging them.

"That cannot be right."

Pivr stared at Tersk as the Prognugator of the Armored Antinium paused with the history book in his hands. Tersk didn't reply. He was staring in

shock at the words on the page. He had not known the history of the Second Antinium War in any great detail. To hear of an army destroyed so easily—

“An entire army? Destroyed by a Goblin?”

He looked up and across the campfire at the blue Antinium sitting there. Xrn looked up, her eyes shining with bright orange and red lights that illuminated the dark night like distant stars.

“Prognugator Xrn. Is this true?”

“It cannot be! We cannot have lost to *Goblins!*”

Pivr insisted loudly. He fanned his wings in agitation, moving around the fire and grabbing for the book Tersk was reading from.

“Give me that.”

He snatched the book and read the passage. He recoiled in disbelief and turned to Xrn.

“This book is lying. It must be.”

“Must it? Why must it lie, Pivr? Because you do not like the truth? This Krsysl Wordsmith exaggerates his history and twists the facts to suit his narrative, but he does not make up false events. Tallis Stormbreaker destroyed the first army we sent against him. And the second and third.”

The other Antinium stared at Xrn in horrified silence. Pivr’s wings fanned wide and his mandibles leaked a bit of the acidic bile he had been engineered to produce. Tersk snatched the book back before the acid could land on it.

“That is—we are the Antinium. We cannot be defeated so easily. You were there! This book said you led the first army. How could you have allowed him to triumph?”

The Antinium went still. Xrn sat up slowly and Pivr broke off speaking, realizing he might have erred. He backed up a bit as the warm lights in Xrn's eyes became cold, turning blue and frosty grey.

“Allowed? I allowed him nothing, Pivr. The Stormbreaker *took*. That was the might of the Goblin King and his Goblin Lords. They destroyed the army I led against them, and I was helpless to fight back. We underestimated the Goblins, Pivr. We did not know what they could do. As it says in the book, Tallis broke my army with a single spell.”

“How?”

Tersk leaned forwards, his hands shaking on the book. He'd read ahead and seen no details of the battle. Xrn looked at him and the cold lights in her eyes changed. They became a swirling vortex, a mass of colors vanishing into a pinpoint in the center of her eyes. Tersk shuddered and looked away, but Xrn's voice was kind and sad as she replied.

“Oh, it was very simple. Tallis Stormbreaker was the Goblin King's personal [Shaman]. He possessed the might of his people and his magic reflected that. When we charged his army he cast one spell. One simple spell, with such a simple effect.”

Xrn looked past the others, into the depths of the fire. The wind began to blow as she continued, her voice lost in the past.

“He opened a hole in the sky.”

There was a hole in the sky. A hole as small as your hand at first. So small you'd never see it. But then it grew, widening until the clouds were sucked into it, until it became a vortex, a gaping rift that dragged

everything upwards, tearing up trees, sucking up rocks and dirt and everything below it.

Xrn saw the spiral appear in the sky as the Antinium army around her surged across the dry flatlands. They charged towards the Goblin army, towards the Goblin [Shaman] whose hands shone like the sun.

So brave. So simple. Xrn screamed at them to stop. She raised her staff and tried to dispel the grand magic overhead. But it was like throwing all her weight against a mountain. The hole in the sky widened and then began to pull.

Antinium Soldiers, racing across the ground in the tens of thousands, began to slow as they lost their traction on the ground. And then they lost their footing and began to float. Xrn saw their arms flailing in confusion as the winds blew them upwards. She heard the howl now, a terrible sound that was louder than a tornado and deeper than the roar of the ocean. The sky tore and her army was sucked into that void in space.

Across the battlefield, Tallis Stormbreaker raised his arms and the gyre widened further. Sea and sky became one. Xrn looked up, her magics barely keeping her rooted as Workers and Soldiers were pulled helplessly into the air. Even the Flying Antinium were at the mercy of the winds—they were dragged into the sky hundreds of miles up and hurled down into the ground.

The Goblin Lord laughed and his laughter was thunder. Xrn hurled fire at him, but the other Goblin [Shamans] and [Mages] broke her spells and hurled spells at her. She fled as her army fell up.

There was only horrified silence as Xrn finished her story. The Antinium sat frozen around the campfire as the wind blew in sympathy for

Xrn's tale. The Small Queen looked up and met Tersk's eyes.

"We did not know of Goblins. We did not know of the Goblin King or what his armies could do. We underestimated them and paid for it."

"But how? How could they be so strong?"

Tersk's voice shook as he looked at the book he held. Xrn shrugged; she had no easy answer. She stared at the Prognugator of the Armored Antinium, wondering if her story had broken his spirit. But to her surprise Pivr spoke up.

"If that was the power the Goblin Lords held, how could we defeat them, Prognugator Xrn? For we surely did not retreat. The Antinium do not retreat. How did we fight them? How did we win?"

She looked at Pivr, surprised. The Revalantor of the Flying Antinium fanned his wings, his multi-faceted eyes ablaze with passion. For all his faults, he was brave. So Xrn answered him truthfully, drawing her answer from both past and present.

"It was a grand spell that Tallis Stormbreaker used. He could not call upon it the second time we sent an army towards him, nor the third. He still broke our armies with his magics, but he grew more exhausted with each spell he cast. The Antinium could have paid the price that way, taking his life with mountains of our dead. Or if we had had more of our great warriors of old, more of our lost technology, we could have overwhelmed him with might. As it was, the Grand Queen chose neither option. She looked at the Goblins as a threat and gave her Prognugators three separate orders. Klbkch, Wrymvr, and I were ordered to break the Goblin King's might at any cost."

"And did you?"

Pivr's gaze was steady. Xrn's mandibles opened and lifted. She smiled at him and the other Antinium and nodded at the book.

"Read and find out. But my presence should be all the answer you need."

Three armies. Three disastrous defeats, against a single Goblin Lord no less! The Antinium had been humbled, and at last, after three total routs of her forces, the Grand Queen finally reconsidered the mindless tactics her armies had employed. She ceased battling the Goblin Lord's army in open engagements and instead began harassing the Goblins in the south of Izril, attacking them at night, through tunnels and with her Silent Antinium, wearing them down as her armies kept a stranglehold on the Drake cities on the eastern front.

The Goblins, perhaps unaware of the situation within Izril, must have received a shock to find such a widespread and fearless enemy already vying for control of the continent. In many ways, the Antinium resembled the Goblins with their overwhelming numbers, general lack of intelligence, repulsiveness...but any hope of an alliance between the two verminous species was ruined with the first battle with Tallis Stormbreaker. They became enemies, which in turn eased the pressure off the Human and Drake defenders as these two powers collided.

Much like the Goblin King, Tallis Stormbreaker was too powerful to rout in a single pitched battle, as his command of massive battlefield-wide spells was especially suited to destroying the Antinium. However, by the same token, his armies failed to uproot the Antinium who would flee the Goblin Lord and then destroy lesser Goblin armies with their ceaseless suicidal attacks.

And meanwhile, the Necromancer was occupied at Liscor, battling with Zel Shivertail. The southern continent of Izril was deadlocked, dear readers, which, sadly, forces us to refocus once more on the Human battles with the Goblins to the north.

The Goblin King's advance had slowed and even been turned away for the first time at the city of First Landing, although at great cost. Now the Goblin King's forces split up. Unable to take the city, they began burning and pillaging in a wide radius around the continent, attempting to force the Humans into a pitched battle which they might win, or slowly wear the Humans down.

Several of the Goblin Lords marched west, burning a path across the continent. The rest clashed with the Human defenders. The new generation of [Lords] and [Ladies] showed some resistance here, as Lord Tyrion Veltras demonstrated his military competency against the Goblins and Magnolia Reinhart employed numerous artifacts to slow the Goblin's progress.

But there were too many Goblins and the Humans were unable to slow their progress. It seemed as if the Goblin King's armies might well destroy the entire continent as they also marched east, undeterred by the Humans' desperate and uncoordinated resistance. But here they ran into yet another obstacle, this time in the shape of a famous ally from across the world. It was as Greydath of Blades was threatening to defeat a small army of Humans on the Plains of Saltes that he appeared on the battlefield, surprising the world at large and Greydath in particular.

Niers Astoragon, the Titan. The small [Strategist] of Baleros reportedly strode onto the battlefield and made his presence known by taking command of the Human army. It is unknown how he arrived so quickly across the world—especially given how he was seen in Baleros one day prior to this battle. Travelling so far and so fast is practically impossible,

and yet the Fraerling [Strategist] managed it somehow. For reference, the most world-famous Couriers making use of the fastest ships and artifacts still require at least four days to make the journey across from Baleros to Izril, and that is only the sea voyage.

It is speculated that he must have had a particularly powerful scroll of [Teleportation] or employed the services of some exceptionally powerful mage or group of mages—and it is noted that all of Wistram's [Mages] deny helping the Titan at this juncture—but whatever the case, the Titan used the surprise his appearance had caused to push Greydath's army back and win one of the first victories for the Humans.

This was not the only battle Niers Astoragon would win either. The tiny second-in-command of one of the Four Great Companies quickly assumed control of the Human armies in the area and proceeded to win or stalemate the Goblin Lords in the area. This sudden rallying in the east gave the Humans a second wind, despite the obvious irony that they were placing their hopes on such tiny shoulders. Still, this writer supposes that if any shoulders were equal to the burden, it was those of Niers Astoragon, the Titan of Baleros himself.

The Titan is, of course, famed for having defeated one of the King of Destruction's Seven, the Gambler of Fates, Queravia, among his other accomplishments, but he rose to greater heights during the Second Antinium War. As one of the highest-level [Strategists] in the world, he was able to fight on the same level with the Goblin Lords and his grasp of strategy would see him outmaneuvering the Goblin Lords, despite possessing a weaker or less numerous force in the battles he fought.

It is unknown why Niers Astoragon chose to risk his life as he did and fight the Goblin King's armies head on, especially since Baleros was already in the process of sending armies across the sea to defend Izril.

Perhaps it was guilt that prompted the Titan to fight directly against the Goblin King.

After all, it was his company who first agreed to peace with Velan the Kind when he was a Goblin Lord. The Fraerling [Strategist] must have been attempting to repay his considerable debt to the people of the world, and it has to be said, his impact on the battlefield was not as minute as his stature. He pushed back the armies of two Goblin Lords at once, fending both off with the skill that prompts some to call him the greatest [Strategist] in the world.

However, as with all non-Drake heroes, it appears Niers Astoragon had a fatal flaw. In this case, it was that of cowardice, for he refused to do battle with the Goblin King. Velan the Kind appeared on battlefields across Izril, pushing his armies east, south, north and west, his armies enjoying victory after victory when he fought among them. And whenever he would appear on the eastern fronts, Niers Astoragon would retreat from battle, allowing the Goblin King to gobble up cities and entire provinces rather than risk any kind of engagement with him.

Shockingly, it appeared that the Titan's spine was far weaker than that of the lowest-level Drake [Soldier], as he would go on to end the Second Antinium War without ever participating in a battle where the Goblin King was present.

When questioned about his fearful retreat from any actual conflict with the Goblin King, the much-vaunted [Strategist] of Baleros had only this to say:

"I'm not an idiot."

He then refused to reply to any of the letters this humble [Writer] sent to him, leaving this questionable page in history unfortunately blank. At least Niers Astoragon's strategy bought time for the Humans, but in the larger

scale of things, his retreats allowed the Goblins an equal number of effortless victories, balancing his contributions out on the whole. Whether his aid was truly that monumental is a debate for [Tacticians], but this Drake has his own doubts on the matter.

“That clod-footed village-smasher. I *told* him not to print that!”

Niers Astoragon frowned down at the tiny book in his hands. He considered ripping it up, but books were expensive, and books that were made for Fraerlings were hard to obtain. They were almost twice as expensive, in fact—not because of the costs of production, which were minute, but because a Fraerling [Bookbinder] and [Scribe] had to labor hard to copy texts in miniature.

So he reluctantly put the book down before he tossed it into the burning wax candle that sat next to him. Niers got up and paced about the table, kicking aside a tea bag as he vented his emotions.

A large furry hand reached down and picked up the tea bag. Foliana, sitting at Niers’ table in his quarters, raised the tea bag and began nibbling at it. She had no tea cup. In fact, she had nothing to drink at all. She did have a muffin, which she held in her other hand.

“Mm. He doesn’t like you.”

“Who? The author? He does not. I’ve met petty Drakes, but including all that nonsense because I refused to let him interview me and entertain all his idiotic questions? That’s a new low.”

Niers scowled but tromped back to his miniature armchair, sighing as he picked the book up and sat back in his chair. He looked up at Foliana as she perched on a much larger stool by their table.

It was a custom the two had to sit together and relax when they could. In this case, the relaxing component was debatable, but Niers still thought it was important to keep reading. He grunted as he flipped through the pages, trying to find where he'd last been reading.

"This business with the Goblin Lord has me uneasy, Foliana. There are too many parallels to the past. Zel Shivertail, Magnolia Reinhart..."

"Could be her plans. She did want to involve us."

"True. I just don't know...oh come now. 'Fraerling courage is clearly in short supply?' He calls himself a *writer*? This is the most biased, petty—"

Foliana reached down and patted Niers on the head. He shoved her paw away, irritated. She shrugged and went back to consuming the tea bag. After the Fraerling had calmed he looked up at Foliana and sighed.

"He is right on one count, though. We did allow this. If I had any inkling that Velan would have become *this*, I would have destroyed his tribe when we first met him."

"Would have been tricky. He was strong back then."

"And *sane*. Dead gods, Foliana, what happened to him?"

"Became Goblin King. Went crazy."

Foliana shrugged, nibbling at the tea grounds. Niers frowned. He stroked at his beard, thinking hard.

"There has to be more to it than that. You met Velan once, Foliana. What did you think of him?"

"Sane. Smart. Kind. Like his name. Cared about his people. Also strong."

Niers grunted.

“That was my impression as well. He was so calm and intelligent for a Goblin that I found myself taken with him in an instant. His sudden change though...it’s one of the mysteries I intend to unravel.”

“Like chess? And the dungeon?”

“All of it fits together somehow, Foliana. I’m sure of it. If I only had time, I’d go to that new dungeon in Liscor, and the old one they found in Terandria. I could put together clues. But there’s never enough time, is there?”

The Titan sighed, and Foliana broke off a piece of her strawberry muffin and offered it to him. He took a crumb the size of his head and chewed on it glumly.

“I suppose it does seem cowardly, doesn’t it? But I knew any battle with Velan would be disastrous, so I did what I could. The army I had to work with was dispirited and lacked unity. I couldn’t see any way to pin down Velan without him tearing a hole in every formation I sent at him. Do you think I was wrong not to try to occupy him?”

Foliana was silent as she sat on her chair. The candle dripped beads of wax slowly until she began to nibble at the candle as well. Niers snapped at her and she abandoned eating the candle and spoke at last.

“Niers, you remember what I told you when all the others were telling us to come fight, don’t you? They wanted us to send our company to Izril. Across the oceans. I said no. I don’t like water and you were there. That was enough.”

“I recall you saying so. You refused to cross to Izril.”

“Mm. And you know why that is?”

“Besides you not liking water?”

“Mhm. But also another reason. Do you know?”

“No. Why didn’t you go?”

Foliana stopped nibbling at her muffin and looked at Niers with her tri-colored eyes.

“I’m not an idiot either. Even if he ate muffins, I would get killed before I scratched him.”

She sat back on her chair. Niers looked thoughtfully at the book in front of him and then frowned.

“This author really is insufferable. Yes, we were in full retreat. But that was in the expectation of reinforcements! Which we received, I might add! You remember, don’t you, Foliana? We were negotiating for every company we could get to cross the seas, and then—”

“I remember. I offered them a muffin if they’d go.”

“I recall that. You need to work on your tact or let our [Emissaries] sort negotiations out, Foliana. I can’t believe you got the companies to actually agree to help. How did you do it? And don’t tell me it was a muffin.”

“It was.”

“They sailed across the sea and fought the Goblin King for a muffin?”

“Well, it was made of gold. And I did offer them a few baskets.”

While the Goblin King’s armies pursued the Humans across the continent, the world was slowly beginning to wake up to his threat. The desperate pleas from the Humans and Drake requests for assistance went

largely ignored in Chandrar, who had seen too much death from the King of Destruction already. But Baleros, enraged by the Goblin King's treachery, had sent countless mercenary companies across the ocean. Rhir sent a small army as well, honoring the treaties as the Blighted King always has, but it was Terandria who was first to act.

The shorter distance between Terandria and Izril and the continent's own history with the previous Goblin King, Curulac of a Hundred Days, meant that the normally short-sighted [Kings] and [Queens] were aware of the Goblin threat from the start. Thus, an army of two hundred thousand Terandrians landed on the northern shores of Izril at the end of the summer.

They met the Goblin King's forces right away. Velan the Kind had been caught off-guard by the Humans' arrival and was in the middle of pulling his forces back to face this new threat. To buy time, he personally assailed the Terandrians as they were landing ships with five thousand of his Goblin elites.

This writer realizes that the idea of five thousand Goblins attacking a force numbering over two hundred thousand seems ludicrous, but the Goblin King was cut of the same cloth that the King of Destruction, Flos, was made of. Tales of his ability in battle are widespread, and this writer will omit any tedious recitals of his feats in combat. Suffice it to say that the Goblin King was known for defeating enemy [Generals] and [Mages] in combat, and his Goblin elites were similarly powerful.

The vanguard he led into battle was comprised of Hobs who were all as powerful as Gold-rank adventurers. They carried magical weapons and armor into battle and some were reportedly as tall as half-Giants. Whether these rumors are entirely accurate is unknown, but they were certainly a force to be reckoned with, as the Terandrians found to their cost.

The sheer daring of the attack on their ships caught the Terandrians unawares. The Goblin King managed to sink several ships before the

Terandrians drove him off, and he successfully beat back the Terandrians in battle after battle, once again proving the futility of placing any kind of hope on Humans.

However, the Terandrian forces were only the first wave. More fleets began arriving on Izril, all of whom began to come under immediate attack the instant they landed, sometimes before they reached ground. The Goblin King's armies reformed into a spear that fought off the foreign armies, and the war in the north became a stalemate.

Yes, even with so many continents lending their aid, the battle against the Goblin King had only shifted from a losing battle into one on equal footing. Worse, it was feared that Tallis Stormbreaker would abandon his campaign to the south to support Velan the Kind.

The [Shaman] in the south had broken the Drakes and Antinium forces sent against him. And though the Antinium had stymied his forces, the Goblins would soon strike the larger blow. After a series of Antinium strikes against his forces, the Goblin King personally appeared in the south. He swiftly encircled an Antinium Hive and after wiping out all the Antinium on the surface, led his army into the Hive and slew the Queen inside himself.

The fact that the Goblin King had succeeded in the very tactic that had cost so many lives of Drake armies must have shaken the Antinium terribly, for they immediately ceased attacking the Goblin King's armies and pulled back all their armies to defend their remaining Hives. This cessation of assaults meant that Tallis Stormbreaker was free to maneuver his armies, which in turn gave him the opportunity to move through the High Passes and join the fighting in the north if he so chose.

If the Goblins had concentrated all their forces in the north, the continent might have been lost entirely, especially because the Necromancer had cut off the only safe land route north. And as the fighting drew into fall, it seemed like the Drakes might lose Liscor for good. No aid had reached

the embattled forces of Zel Shivertail—Tallis Stormbreaker’s armies lay in the way, as did the Antinium forces. Zel Shivertail’s urgent missives were met with denials or silence from the Drake cities. Day by day his forces decreased and the Necromancer’s increased.

But still, Liscor fought! Against all odds, dear readers, the Siege of Liscor had continued not for days, not for weeks, but for three months by the time they had reached the breaking point! Every adult in Liscor had taken to the walls during this time, and Zel Shivertail’s army continued to assail the Necromancer, holding the battle lines and shielding Liscor from the full brunt of his attacks.

Yes, if there is any battle to commemorate the spirit of Drakes, it would be that one. A single Drake [Spearman] would stop a charging Draugr that Gold-rank adventurers might struggle to subdue. The Drake civilians, led by the core of their army, fended off wraith attacks and the undead giants with their indomitable spirit.

What courage, what valorous acts must have been seen every day! This writer longs to have been there, to see the heroism of Drakes at our finest. Despite the dark hour, the Necromancer had yet to take the city. And though it seemed like the final blow would be struck any day now, the Drakes still held on. Valiant, undeterred, full of the courage that is such a byword of the Drake species as a whole—

“Grandma, you’re grinding your teeth. If you don’t stop, I’m taking the book away.”

Selys Shivertail sighed and looked up, unable to take the noise any longer. She didn’t live with her grandmother in the same apartment—that would have been a nightmare—but she visited the elderly Drake often. Selys usually found herself in her grandmother’s home at least once a week.

She told herself it was because she liked her grandmother, Tekshia Shivertail. And that was true, but it was *also* true that Tekshia Shivertail was the Guildmaster of the Adventurer's Guild in Liscor. In other words, she was Selys' boss as well as her grandmother and she wasn't shy about withholding Selys' pay unless her granddaughter showed up regularly.

It usually wasn't a problem, but Selys would rather be out partying on a night like tonight. Instead, she was stuck with her grandmother, listening to the old Drake's teeth grind and her tail thrashing.

"Stop reading that history book, Grandma. You always get mad when you do, and remember what the [Healer] said?"

Tekshia Shivertail looked up. Her scales were grayer and had a lot less luster than Selys', but she was still spry and quite attractive with her dusky purple coloration. She lashed her tail irritably as she glared at her granddaughter across the table.

"What the [Healer] said? He said I'm in better shape than *you* are, girl. I'm fit, you're not. I can still outrun half the Gnolls in this city and you're too lazy to get out of bed until the sun's halfway overhead!"

"...Right. But he said that you get angry and that's a bad thing."

"For other people maybe!"

Tekshia slammed a fist onto the table and Selys jumped.

"Yeah, and I'm *other people*, Grandma! Remember when you sent that poor Gnoll to the healer's?"

"What of it? I have a right to be angry, especially when I read this nonsense!"

Tekshia waved the book angrily at Selys. Her granddaughter peered at the book.

“What’s that? The Second History of the Antinium Wars? I thought the author was very complimentary about us.”

“He is. Too much! That idiot’s practically licking our feet and wagging his tail over our ‘heroic sacrifice’. Heroic? There was nothing heroic about the siege and the Necromancer! It was the most miserable, nightmarish three months I’ve ever lived through and I’ve lived a long time! But to hear this Wordsmith fellow tell it, we were all having a grand time! Here, just listen to that.”

Selys’ grandmother read the offending passage out loud and Selys winced.

“Okay, he might not understand how battles work. I don’t think this Drake has ever seen a zombie, much less anything scarier than that.”

Tekshia snorted, her tail curling around the leg of her chair in irritation.

“That’s clear enough. A single Drake [Spearman] stopping a charging Draugr? *Hah!* Those damn things will run down the length of your spear and gut you before you can blink twice! And fighting off wraiths with swords? What does this [Writer] think we did, yell at them and hurt their feelings?”

“At least he thinks we’re heroes. It could be worse.”

Selys tried to calm her grandmother down, but Tekshia was too incensed to let up. She got up, muttering, and poured herself some tea, angrily spilling some on the book.

“Ancestors take it! Get me a cloth before the ink runs, Selys. Not that one! That’s my good cloth! Yes, that! Bring it over here!”

She dabbed at the pages of the book with the second-best cloth as Selys sighed loudly. Tekshia ignored her and went on.

“Being called heroes is almost as bad as cowards. And he completely neglected to mention how we felt! It’s as if our situation didn’t matter, as if we could hold our ground despite the odds! We were *begging* for reinforcements. But oh no, he would have everyone thinking we were just too lazy to beat the Necromancer when he was slaughtering us day by day!”

She ground her teeth again, sipping at her tea and making a hissing sound deep in her throat.

“If that coward—this Wordsmith fellow ever dared come here, we’d show him what we think about his ‘history’ book. It’s a shame our army isn’t near his home, or I’d ask a few of the boys to go to his house and teach him a lesson.”

“Grandma!”

Selys shot out of her chair and glared at Tekshia, looking horrified. The older Drake was unapologetic.

“What? A few sticks and rocks and a beating is how we used to settle things! Street justice is swifter than the Watch—and more efficient too! It’s not like I’d ask them to kill him—just break his hands, maybe.”

“That’s just as bad!”

“Is it? He can write what he wants and get away with it and we can’t tell him how we feel? Not while I’m alive. Get me my quill and ink and some parchment, would you, Selys dear?”

“Absolutely not.”

Selys folded her arms. Tekshia eyed the younger Drake balefully, but then relented.

“You’re right. I’ll send a [Message] spell instead. Much quicker. Anyways, at least this Wordsmith fellow got one thing right.”

Tekshia opened the book again, ignoring her granddaughter's spluttering. She tapped one claw approvingly on a line in the book.

"It was Zel Shivertail who rallied us. Without him, we would have been lost. That much is true."

"Uncle Zel? He never talks about the battle around me. What was it like with him fighting the Necromancer? Was he really as big a hero as everyone says he was?"

Selys leaned over the table, peering at the book. Tekshia tilted the page to show Selys. She sighed, her anger giving way to nostalgia.

"He was a giant. That silly young Drake with his battered armor, fighting on the front lines, surrounded by undead. Taking shots from Az'kerash himself and standing right back up and charging back into the fray—how could we not follow him? I remember when he would visit the city as a child. That hatchling became a fine [General]. So long as he stood, we could keep fighting."

"It's so strange. He never mentions any of that to me. He's just Uncle Zel when he visits. He eats pies, beats up [Thugs]—I can't ever picture him being a big hero on the battlefield."

Selys shook her head and Tekshia smacked her niece's claws before Selys could reach for a fruit tart.

"Those are *mine*, you thieving little hatchling! If you want a snack then bring me those 'cookies' or some of that 'cake' you keep bragging about eating! Honestly, if you know this Human [Innkeeper] so well you could at least bring me some of her cooking! And you don't know how important your uncle is because you've never been on any battlefield! If you wanted to know what it was like, why didn't you ask him when he visited?"

“Uncle Zel never talks about the siege, Grandma. He’s too embarrassed whenever people come up to thank him.”

“That hatchling. We’re *grateful* to him. But he’s just like your father used to be. Embarrassed when people praise him for what he did. It explains why he left without visiting me.”

“He visited you once, Grandma.”

“*Once!* Hah! He’s fearless on the battlefield, but he can’t handle me asking him about marriage! I keep telling him to settle down with a nice young Drake or at least have sex—he doesn’t have to marry them! He can make a few hatchlings and then—”

“*Grandmother!*”

Selys glared at her grandmother, scandalized. The old Drake flicked her tail at Selys’ face.

“You prudish youngsters! You’re all so *timid*. What happened to all the real Drakes? The kind who’d never bend their tails for any threat, who’d stand tall no matter what tried to beat them down? Your mother was as brave as could be, and she wasn’t shy about grabbing your father. And I’m sure they would have given me at least one more grandchild if—if—”

Tekshia’s ranting slowed and she stopped, suddenly acutely aware of her audience. Selys’ tail went still and Tekshia cleared her throat, avoiding her eyes.

“I’m sorry dear. I shouldn’t be reading this after all. You’re right. Too many bad memories come up. Especially with the siege. You might be too young to remember it, but—”

“No, I remember.”

Selys closed her eyes. She had been there. She could remember Liscor's siege. Not the fighting, but the hiding in her house, the screams, the wounded and the stench—her grandmother patted Selys on the knee gently.

“I do talk too much, don't I? I'll stop. Let's talk about happier things.”

She made to close the book, but Selys stopped her.

“No, go on. Keep talking. You hardly ever do and no one else will. Tell me about what it was like?”

“Again?”

Selys gulped. The young Drake woman stared at the book and then at her grandmother.

“Yes. Tell me. Tell me about all of it, and the parts you won't tell me. Tell me about my parents. And...how they died.”

A flash of pain crossed over Selys' grandmother's face. Tekshia Shivertail closed the book and closed her eyes for a second. Selys waited, her heart twisting. She had been young then. But she could still remember her grandmother walking through the door, her armor covered in blood. She remembered asking for her parents and seeing the answer in the tears on her grandmother's face.

Once. Tekshia looked away, raising a claw to scratch at the greyed scales on her neck.

“I told you, they died on the walls. Most of us did. Hah—the Necromancer couldn't break our gates, and he could only send waves up the walls. We held him with spears and swords. Axes too. We'd toss rocks at the Draug that climbed up, cut them down before they could get onto clear ground. Because when they did—”

“That's when it happened?”

The old Drake didn't reply at first. Her voice was distant when she eventually spoke.

"We didn't have enough [Mages]. I keep telling those idiots who run the Walled Cities—I say it all the time. We don't have enough magic-users. Drakes don't take to magic like other species. We say it's dishonorable, too easy—not military. So what? If we had as many [Mages] as we had [Sergeants] in the army we would have beaten the Necromancer without help. Instead, our wonderful army of idiots died one by one as Az'kerash sniped them with spells. And on that day he sent the wraiths to harass us."

Her eyes were distant. Selys remembered the sounds she'd heard from her house. The unearthly screams, the boom of magics, the only thing that could harm the spectral wraiths. And her grandmother's voice went on, softer.

"They cut us down before Zel could get a [Mage] unit in position to help us blast them away. That gave the Necromancer's army time to send up, oh, fifteen of the Draugr into one spot. Fifteen, and one of those giant Carcass Walkers for good measure. It barely needed to climb to get up. I remember seeing it towering over the others and thinking this was the end."

"But it wasn't."

Selys' grandmother stirred. A bit of anger flashed in her eyes and she sat up.

"Of course not! Your father would never allow it. Your mother either. She was already shooting those Draugr off—using the last of her enchanted arrows. I told her to hold on to them, to wait for a good shot to put one between the Necromancer's eyes, but her arrows gave us a chance to rally. That brave idiot. If she'd just held onto one rather than save us, then maybe she would have taken the wraith out. But it got her from behind. And your father—"

Selys' eyes were dry. She'd heard the story too many times. But her claws scraped at each other as she gripped her hands tightly together. Her grandmother's eyes were distant, her head turned to the very walls.

"Your father saw the Carcass Walker start tearing us apart. And more undead were coming up the walls. The Necromancer knew we were about to break so he sent everything he had at us. Another minute and the Walker would have cleared us all off. So your father charged into it. He used a Skill —[Ram's Charge], that silly, silly move. And he knocked it off the walls. And he went over with it."

"And did he—when he fell, I mean. Was it—"

Selys' throat closed over the next word. Was it quick? Her heart was twisting like her hands, twisting and twisting until she thought it might snap. But it never did. It just hurt. Tekshia shook her head.

"I don't know. I was fighting—I couldn't look around. Your father was brave, strong—I have to imagine he survived. He must have taken down a score of them before they overwhelmed him. We never found his body, but he must have—"

Her voice trailed off. For a second she looked so lost. Selys hugged her. Tekshia stiffened, and then came back to reality. She was still for a second and then her voice returned to its usual snappishness.

"Enough sobbing over the past. Your parents died like the heroes they always were, Selys. We might have all died had the siege gone on a day longer. It wasn't glorious; we fought because we had no choice. We fought and died, and only those of us who were *there* will ever know what it was like. And no idiotic [Writer] can change that."

She busied herself around her kitchen, pushing the plate of tarts towards Selys. The young Drake woman took one and chewed it slowly, coming back from those dark times. Tekshia's mood returned to normal too, and

soon she was grouching about incompetent adventurers, who had been stronger, smarter, faster, and cleaner back when she'd been young.

“It’s a disgrace when there’s not one Gold-rank adventurer in Liscor who’s a Drake! Not one! Where did all our adventurers go? And just look at the Human ones who keep coming here! Now we have [*Necromancers*] walking about the city! I can’t understand why you tolerate that Human one, Selys. *You* of all people!”

Selys sighed, predicting another argument with her grandmother. She adopted a patient, if slightly strained, tone.

“He saved my life, Grandma. During the attack on Liscor by the undead. And before you say anything it wasn’t his fault! He saved me and Erin too and he killed more undead than anyone else I saw that night.”

“So? Thank him and then kick him out of the city, that’s what I say! But no, he’s just a nuisance, not a threat. Ridiculous. At least you could kick him out rather than letting him in the Guild! If your father and mother could see you now, holding tails with a [*Necromancer*]...”

“*Grandma!* I’m not dating him!”

Selys rolled her eyes and her grandmother grunted. She returned to the book, flipping through pages. And again, the past uncurled and swept through the room, reaching out from the parchment and engulfing the two Drakes. Tekshia’s voice was soft as she spoke to herself and her granddaughter.

“Yes, it felt like it was over that day. We had the wall, but the Necromancer was still pushing, and Zel couldn’t get to us this time. Not enough soldiers. We were going to break, I felt it.”

“Just like that?”

“You say it as if we hadn’t been on the verge for months. This was it. We didn’t have the strength to fight for another day and night without rest, Selys. I was thinking of you, thinking of trying to get away with you when the lines fell, get you to Zel and away from the battle if I could. And that’s when we heard the horn calls in the distance. We turned, and saw them.”

Tekshia’s claw closed on her teacup, so hard that the ceramic cracked. She didn’t notice. She stared into the distance and Selys remembered too. The shouting, the screams, and then the cheering.

“There they were, Selys. We thought they were our doom when we first saw them from afar. But then we realized they were our salvation. They came down like the sea itself and broke the Necromancer’s armies. That is why we opened our gates to them. That is why we signed the treaty here. Because they saved us.”

Selys nodded. She stared at the book, which was so complimentary of the Drakes of Liscor and had omitted one of the most important points. Zel Shivertail was a hero of Liscor, true enough. But Liscor had another hero, whose tale was largely untold in this historical narrative. They had broken the siege, delivered the people of Liscor from the Necromancer at the last moment. The most unexpected of allies, those strange invaders from another continent, another world.

“The Antinium.”

S02 – The Antinium Wars (Pt.5)

“The Black Tide! The Black Tide marches!”

“The Antinium are to the south! Watch the walls!”

“Rally on me!”

Zel Shivertail’s voice was a roar as he turned his soldiers to face the new threat. His heart sank as he saw the waves of black bodies marching towards the city, a seemingly endless mass of Soldiers. Liscor didn’t have the strength to fight two enemies! And even if the Antinium overwhelmed the Necromancer, what then?

There was one desperate shred of hope that Zel clung to. He unfurled the dirty little bit of parchment the Courier had sent him two days ago, the mysterious note from the Drake High Command. It had one simple message that had infuriated and puzzled Zel. After his countless requests for assistance, they had sent him a single reply that consisted of one line:

Prepare for irregular reinforcements.

The parchment crumpled as Zel clenched his fist. He stared at the approaching Antinium army. This couldn’t be what they’d meant, could it?

There was someone leading the Antinium, a figure that stood out from the rest. Klbkch the Slayer stood at the head of his army, two silvery swords in his hands. He alone carried weapons; the other Antinium were uniform. He raised his voice and Zel could hear it, amplified by some spell or Skill over the battlefield.

“Our target is Az’kerash, the Necromancer! Soldiers, the Drakes are allies for this battle! Do not injure any Drake soldier for any reason! Now! Target the Necromancer’s position! Destroy his undead army! The first rank will charge!”

The Antinium moved like lightning. Before the Drake army and the undead had quite digested what was happening the Soldiers in the first rank were already charging across the ground towards the Necromancer’s army. The undead turned to meet the Soldiers and the Antinium crashed into them like a breaking wave.

Zombies were crushed in an instant while Draugr held their ground and grappled with the Soldiers. Zel, frozen, saw one monstrous, hulking undead crush a Soldier before two more bore it down. The Soldiers stomped on the fallen undead, brutally pounding them with their fists. But the undead army was full of horrors and the Soldiers stalled. Again, Klbkch’s voice echoed as he raised one of his swords.

“The second rank will charge!”

Another wave of Soldiers set forth. This one raced towards the undead just like the first. Zel expected them to slow and join the fighting, but the Soldiers didn’t slow down. The Drake gaped.

“Are they insane? They’re going to hit—”

The second wave crashed into the backs of the first wave of Soldiers, not slowing even as they ran into the backs of their comrades. They trampled ally and enemy alike, pushing forwards without regard for casualties on their side. The undead were unprepared for the savage momentum that carried the Soldiers forwards, and their lines began to cave in.

“Dead gods! They’re actually doing it!”

The undead formations that had withstood Zel's army were crumbling, unprepared for the savagery of the Antinium. Zel could see the Necromancer, shielded by a Bone Giant, turning in surprise. Zel thought he could see Az'kerash's eyes widening in surprise as the Antinium ignored Zel's forces altogether.

"The third rank will charge!"

Klbkch's voice heralded another wave of Antinium. Zel saw them coming, saw the undead buckling and knew this was it. He raised his fist into the air and roared so all his soldiers could hear him.

"All forces, follow me! This is it! Hit the Necromancer! Bring him down!"

He sprinted to the front of the line and smashed into a pair of Draug. The Drakes behind him, caught up in the surge of momentum from the Antinium, roared and poured into the breach. Zel heard Drakes on Liscor's walls cheering, saw arrows flying from the walls and the spells blasting into the Necromancer's army.

Az'kerash held his ground, trying to stop the attacks from Zel and Klbkch's armies. But then Liscor's gates opened and a group of Drakes poured out. Attacked from three sides, his army was engulfed. And Zel, fighting through the undead, found himself face-to-face with the Necromancer for the first and last time in the battle.

"You!"

Az'kerash was cutting down Drakes and Antinium with black magic, reanimating their corpses and hurling them at his enemies. He snarled as he saw Zel and he turned to run. He fired a jet black beam of energy at Zel's head.

The Drake ducked and lunged. He shouted as his claws swiped left to right.

“[Antimagic Slash]!”

His blow caught the Necromancer on the chest and tore through whatever protection the mage had on him. Az’kerash stumbled as Zel laid his chest open. He snarled.

“You fool! Do you really th—”

Zel’s claws went through his chest. The Tidebreaker roared as he tore the Necromancer apart, throwing both halves of Az’kerash to the ground. There was a moment of stunned silence as the fighting Drakes and Antinium saw the Necromancer falling in two bloody halves and stopped.

And then the undead around Az’kerash stumbled and then began to fall. Zel turned and saw one of the remaining Bone Giants begin to crumble, unable to sustain itself without its master’s mana. He heard cheering and raised his bloody claws, roaring in victory. And then he turned and saw Klbkch, standing across the battlefield, his two silvery swords covered in gore. The two locked eyes as Liscor cheered their heroes.

Drake and Antinium. Zel stared at Klbkch the Slayer for all of three seconds and then charged him with a roar. Klbkch charged as well and the two collided in the center of the battlefield, cutting at each other, shouting as their soldiers tried to pull them apart—

“Wait, what?”

Erin sat up suddenly, the empty bowl of popcorn tumbling to the ground. All the Antinium looked at her and Klbkch broke off.

“Is something wrong, Erin?”

“You two *fought*? I thought you were on the same side! Didn’t you say you went to Liscor because the Grand Queen ordered you to help the Drakes?”

Klbbkch hesitated. He raised one finger.

“Nominally. I was ordered to consider the Necromancer a target and assist the Drakes. However, Zel Shiverail and I had clashed on numerous occasions before this. Our animosity was such that we began fighting despite our victory. It still persists to this day, in fact.”

Erin stared at Klbbkch. She had noticed how neither Zel nor Klbbkch liked being in the same room and how they never met each other’s eyes, but this?

“What did you do? I know you didn’t kill him, but—was it just like hitting each other a few times?”

“No. I believe I stabbed him in the chest before our forces separated us. With this sword.”

Klbbkch indicated the sword on his left and then paused. He unsheathed the sword on his right and stared hard at it.

“Or was it this one? I cannot recall.”

He looked at Erin’s gaping mouth and shrugged.

“What? He survived. And he tore off my arm. I was quite upset about that.”

“But you *stabbed*—”

Erin’s voice rose, but before she could shout someone poked her in the side. She looked over and saw Bird glaring reproachfully at her. The Worker raised a finger to his mandibles.

“You are interrupting the story. Be shush.”

He shushed her, ignoring Pawn, Belgrade, Anand, and Garry’s horrified looks. Erin stared at Bird and then looked back at Klbkch. She coughed.

“Sorry. Go ahead, Klbkch.”

The Revalantor nodded and flicked to the next page.

“As I was saying, that battle marked the end of the Necromancer’s threat, as well as the end of hostilities between the Antinium and Drakes. At least for the duration of the war. For our aid against the Necromancer and promise of aid against the Goblin King, we signed a peace treaty. The terms of which included establishing a Hive in Liscor.”

“And they agreed to that? Really?”

Erin raised her voice. Bird reached out to poke her but Pawn slapped his hand. The two Workers stared at each other as Klbkch nodded.

“Neither Zel Shivertail nor I liked the peace, but we did abide by it. Well, eventually...”

The unexpected arrival of the Antinium had saved Liscor and prompted an opportunity to turn the war around for the Drake High Command. Against the urgings of Zel Shivertail and a number of Drake [Commanders], they signed a peace treaty with the Grand Queen, giving the Antinium a number of small concessions in return for their aid and an immediate cease to hostilities. This writer believes any peace with the Antinium is foolish, but at the time the Drakes had no choice. And perhaps the Antinium felt the same way. The Goblin King was too great a threat, and so the Peace at Liscor prompted an unlikely alliance.

What is notable about that period is the reaction of the two leaders in the field at Liscor. Klbkch the Slayer and Zel Shivertail both objected to the peace and engaged in several clashes before their armies separated. However, the rest of the Antinium and Drake armies were able to coordinate without the same incidents occurring. While no Drake army ever fought with an Antinium army, the two sides were able to focus solely on the Goblin King's army and divide targets between themselves.

Now the Goblin King found himself at war with all of Izril, and only now did the tides of fortune begin to turn against him. While the Drakes were occupied with the Necromancer and Antinium they were at the mercy of the Goblins, but now the hammer of the Drake armies was free to march against their foe without needing to guard their tails.

With the Antinium. And the Humans. And some Gnoll tribes. And armies from three other continents who had landed their forces. But it was the Drakes who spearheaded the assaults on the Goblin King's armies! And it was they who drove the Goblins back at last, winning battles, defeating the Goblin Lords in a series of victories!

But never the Goblin King. Alas, the fortitude of the Drake armies had been sapped slightly by the two wars they had fought beforehand and even their [Generals] were unable to defeat the Goblin King in a pitched battle. It became clear that the Goblin King was still unassailable in his main army, which continued to win victory after victory, forcing the defending forces to retreat rather than suffer defeats at his hands.

Part of the issue lay in the scattered nature of the forces fighting against the Goblin King. Some, like the Terandrian armies, had joined with Izril's Humans to create a powerful army while other groups like the Balerosian companies fought alone on their fronts. The Antinium were naturally impossible to work with and the cooperative Drake armies suffered from

numerous communication failures with other forces, leading to a number of uncoordinated attacks and defeats.

In this writer's opinion, part or most of the blame can be assigned to the Humans in the north, who had squandered their advantage by separating their strength. The Five Families of Izril who had united in its last defense against the Goblin King did not fight against him together after the battle.

Instead, each of the five Houses fought against the Goblin King in their own way. Lord Tyrion Veltras pursued an aggressive campaign against the Goblin King with his forces while Magnolia Reinhart focused on linking up with Niers Astoragon's forces and maintaining a defensive perimeter to halt the armies of the Goblin Lords. Had they but worked together, the Goblin King might have fallen sooner. Alas, their disunity cost the continent weeks of continued warfare. A typical Human failure of course; putting their own self-interest before the greater good.

“A poor analysis. But I should expect no better from a [Writer], much less a Drake.”

A cold voice interrupted the narrative. Lord Tyrion looked up as he sat in a chair in the dark candle-lit room. A small voice spoke up by his left hand side.

“Father? Did you really fight with the Reinharts?”

Tyrion Veltras, the famous [Lord] and scion of the Veltras family, looked over at a young boy of nine or ten. The young boy had dark brown hair and a slightly flushed face. He was caught between youthful energy and sickness, so that it seemed as though his vitality couldn't be contained with his frail body.

“Lie back down.”

Tyrion ordered his son and the young boy did so, wheezing gently. Tyrion Veltras paused and an expression of distaste crossed his face as he chose how to reply.

“It was an alliance of necessity, Sammial. I would not ally with Magnolia Reinhart for anything less than the safety of Izril, but in that, she and I are united. For all her many flaws, Magnolia Reinhart is at least dedicated to the safety of the realm, unlike some of our peers. But the way she pursued that safety during the war was at odds with the way I chose to fight. So we separated our forces. It was not a tactical error so much as a necessity; if we had stayed in one place we might have been crushed by the Goblin King, a fact that this author fails to note.”

He turned his gaze to stare at the book, making the man holding the book flinch. However, if Tyrion had hoped his words had impressed the seriousness of the situation on his son, he was instantly disappointed. Sammial shot back up indignantly and glared at his father.

“My name is *Sammy*! I keep telling you and you keep forgetting!”

Lord Tyrion sighed slowly and spoke with clear patience in his tone.

“Sammy is not a name appropriate for a [Lord]. Your name is Sammial, a fine name—”

“It’s *gross*! I want to be Sammy!”

“You will refer to yourself as *Sammial*. Is that clear?”

Lord Tyrion’s eyes flashed and Sammial hesitated. He bowed his head sulkily and lay back, breathing harder. Tyrion eyed his son and turned his head to look at the other occupant of the bed.

“You would do well to copy your older brother, Sammial. Hethon listens before he speaks. Do you have any questions about my strategy, Hethon?”

The other boy in the bed sat up nervously.

“No, Father.”

“Very well.”

Tyrion nodded at his second son, Hethon, who was perhaps fourteen. Hethon didn't have the same sickly complexion as Sammial, but he was thin and nervous, hardly as imposing a figure as his father. Tyrion turned his head and his son breathed a sigh of relief. The [Lord] nodded and spoke in a crisp, commanding voice.

“Continue, Ullim.”

The man sitting across the bed on a stool jumped. The [Majordomo] of the Veltras estate nervously flicked to the next page and read in a steady voice.

Of course, Lord Tyrion was too busy to read to his sons, which was why he had ordered his [Majordomo] to keep them entertained at all times. That normally meant bedtimes as well, but this was a special occasion.

Lord Tyrion's rage upon hearing that Magnolia Reinhart, his hated nemesis, had allied herself with Zel Shivertail had led to the destruction of his personal parlor, including the slashed drapes, broken windows, and two complete suits of armor, now looking quite battle-worn. His anger had frightened his two young sons, which was why he had agreed to sit with them for a bedtime reading.

That was uncharacteristic of Lord Tyrion, who had been absent from the household of late. The loss of his late wife had driven a rift between him and his sons. He was not, Ullim reflected, the most intimate of fathers in any case. Even now he sat on a chair next to his sons' beds rather than in them, sharpening a dagger with a whetstone.

The balding Ullim cleared his throat and read out loud as clearly as he could. He had served the Veltras' for years, as had six generations of his family, but he was aware that a single terrible mistake could end in his dismissal. Lord Tyrion valued loyalty, but he did not tolerate incompetence or betrayal.

“The ah, ‘failing Human armies’ had yet to repel the Goblin King, forcing the Drakes to once again come to their rescue. However, it seemed as though Velan the Kind was determined to fight to the bitter end and his Goblin Lords refused to give in, slaying [Assassins] sent to kill them, beheading Human [Lords] and [Generals], and escaping when defeat threatened their armies. While the Goblin King and his Lords lived, there could be no true victory.”

“Father? Is the Goblin Lord going to destroy Invrisil?”

Ullim stopped reading and Lord Tyrion looked at Hethon. In keeping with his nature, he did not reassure his son, but pondered the question as he would any military matter.

“We shall see if Zel Shivertail’s claws have dulled with age. He was defeated by the Goblin Lord once—I can only trust that he will either repel the Goblin Lord or retreat before the battle is lost.”

He scowled, not reassured by what should have been positive news for his people.

“Either way, I must *hope* that the Goblin Lord’s army remains strong enough to enact my plan. Curse Reinhart. It’s as if she is determined to ruin all of my designs, even the ones she knows nothing of!”

He slapped his knee and sheathed the dagger at his belt in a brisk motion. Hethon and Sammial watched their father, almost as fearfully as Ullim. Tyrion strode towards the windows and stared out into the dark

night. It was Sammial who asked the next question with all the recklessness of youth.

“If the Goblin Lord is strong, how strong is the Goblin King? Could you beat him, Father?”

Ullim flinched and Lord Tyrion turned from the window. His voice was glacial as he replied.

“Most likely not, Sammial. Not without the ancestral relics and more risk than I would care to take. But an intelligent [Lord] would not gamble victory so in any case. The Goblin King was a threat, yes, but he was one that we could deal with. This Drake would have you believe we were struggling to defeat his armies—the truth is that we had a plan and we were enacting it. His forces were pulling back across the continent, giving us concrete targets to strike at, opportunities to rout his forces. We were winning even if we had to sacrifice thousands of soldiers to cut down his own.”

“Why? If he was stronger than everyone else, doesn’t that mean he’d win?”

Sammial wrinkled his nose, confused. Tyrion laughed shortly and shook his head.

“The war was won by numbers and strategy, not the heroics of a single figure, Sammial. The Goblin King had not the strength to fight on so many fronts. Despite his hordes, he left himself exposed. Vulnerable. We could not defeat his main army so we crippled his limbs. We went after his Goblin Lords. Remember that, Sammial, Hethon. If a foe is too strong for you to take on from the front, bleed him to death.”

Lord Tyrion’s eyes blazed fiercely and his children shrank in their beds. Ullim the [Majordomo] thought it was a shame. Even when Tyrion Veltras smiled he still lacked fatherly warmth.

But who better to fight a Goblin King? He had been there, and seen his fall. Ullim gulped and continued reading as Lord Tyrion brooded, recalling the past and the ending of the Second Antinium War.

The strategy that ended the Goblin King was simple: take out his Lords. The Goblin King was, after all, only one Goblin. Like any [King] or [General], he required subordinates to coordinate his massive army efficiently. Additionally, his Goblin Lords were all powerful combatants and their ability to act autonomously had allowed Velan to challenge so many armies at once.

However, with the Antinium and more reinforcements arriving each week, even the Goblin Lords were finally outnumbered. They had to retreat or be overwhelmed from every side. The Goblin King attempted to break through the encircling armies, but Antinium armies advanced from the south, drawing away a good portion of his forces. Wrymvr the Deathless even slew a Goblin Lord in personal combat, further damaging the Goblin King's leadership.

It was the fall of Tallis Stormbreaker that truly told the world the Goblin King was on the verge of defeat. Three Archmages of Wistram cornered the Goblin Lord's army with their own and engaged him in a magical battle that lasted for two days and two nights. On the second day, Xrn the Small Queen and an Antinium force attacked from the Goblin Lord's side. It is thought that the unpredictable magics employed by Xrn combined with the might of Wistram's Archmages overwhelmed Tallis the Stormbreaker. As the Goblin [Shaman] fell, he unleashed a storm which battered Izril for a week with drenching rain and hurricane winds. But he had fallen.

At this point the Goblin King had a handful of Goblin Lords left. It is hard to tell how many truly existed or remained at this point since his Goblin Chieftains could lead huge armies of their own, but the Goblin King had lost many of his vassals and abandoned his multi-sided war across the continent. He formed his remaining forces into one massive army and marched straight towards the combined armies of the world, meeting them in a battle that would last four days and decide the fate of the Antinium Wars.

Eighteen companies from Baleros. An army of [Knights] from Terandria. The battle-hardened forces from Rhir. A small detachment from Chandrar's kingdoms. The might of Wistram. The Humans of Izril and of course, the glorious armies of the Drake cities. This is the force that engaged the Goblin King in the final battle, while smaller forces drew away his Goblin Lords.

It was a daring plan. The Antinium and Niers Astoragon both cut off parts of the Goblin King's army, forcing several of his Lords to battle them and leaving the Goblin King exposed. In that brief window, the allied armies attacked, aiming for one goal and one alone: the death of the Goblin King.

The battle opened with a direct charge on Velan the Kind by six [Generals] and an army of [Knights] and mounted adventurers, including three Named Adventurers. They sought to best him by strength of arms—and failed.

The Goblin King slew two of the [Generals], a [Lord] of Terandria and Ironheart Calecum, the Named Adventurer, in personal combat, forcing the vanguard to retreat in disarray. The Goblin King chased after the retreating soldiers and found himself in a mage bombardment that cut him off from his army.

Unbeknownst to the Goblin King, a separate detachment had been created apart from the main army that was clashing with his forces. It was led by the three Archmages of Wistram and the majority of the high-level [Mages] and [Archers] began to rain death on his position, attempting to destroy the Goblin King at range.

They too failed.

The Goblin King survived the area of attack spells and arrows meant to take his life. However, his personal invincibility did not extend to his army and his vanguard was wiped out to the last Goblin by the powerful spells concentrated on his position. The Goblin King was now left in a precarious position. His army was being subjected to massive attacks from the detachment led by the Archmages, yet any attempt to charge their position led to destruction.

Without Tallis Stormbreaker, the allied world forces had an overwhelming magical advantage that they intended to use to decimate the Goblin King's forces. There was no one who could survive the magical onslaught even at a distance to close and destroy the mages. The end of Velan the Kind seemed to be on hand at last.

“No!”

A groan went up from the Goblins clustered around the book. The lieutenants and former Goblin Chieftains in the Goblin Lord's tent crowded around the open history of the Second Antinium Wars lying on his table. They had found the book faster than Osthia Blackwing had anticipated—raiding cities and libraries for this very copy.

The lone Drake prisoner sat in the Goblin Lord's tent, watching Goblins read their own history. They did not know it, which surprised her. Oh, they

knew the broadest of strokes. They knew their King had been slain, but not how. Now Snapjaw bared her metal teeth, snarling.

“Cowards! They attack from afar! Not fair!”

Fair? Osthia wanted to laugh at her. What was fairness in battle? But she didn’t speak, knowing the mood in the tent was murderous.

And full of grief. The Goblins acted like their King’s death was fresh and personal, which surprised Osthia. They didn’t seem to be acting. But Goblins, grieving over Velan the Kind? It was hard to accept.

“How? How does it happen?”

Another Goblin pushed forwards, a tall Hob. He jabbed at the book. Snapjaw, one of the more literate Hobs in the tent, peered at the book. She read, her face screwing up with the effort.

“It say—Goblins dying. Mages from Wis—Wis Tram attacking. Killing by thousands. Goblin King sees. And he—he—”

She choked on the words. Osthia looked at her, knowing what had happened. But Snapjaw couldn’t say it. Her eyes filled with tears as the others looked at her, prodding her to speak.

“Say! Say!”

“Cannot. Cannot. Too—”

Snapjaw shook her head. A voice interrupted the Goblins as they pestered her.

“Leave her. I know what happened next.”

A Goblin standing apart from the others spoke. Osthia looked around, and saw the Goblin Lord standing, looking out of the tent flaps. Her eyes

narrowed. He hadn't read the book—he'd just listened while the Goblins had torturously read page after page. How could he know?

But he did, somehow. The Goblin Lord turned. His eyes were distant, staring back at another battlefield in the past. All of the Goblins in the tent looked at him. The Goblin Lord's eyes were filled with tears. Osthia stared.

Tears. They were clear and ran down his face from his white pupils. Ordinary tears, bitter and filled with regret. The Goblin Lord answered in place of Snapjaw.

“What did he do next? What he could. The only thing he could. To save his people, for victory, he did all he could do.”

A tear fell from the Goblin Lord's eyes and he caught it. It glimmered in his hand. Wet. Memory. The Goblin Lord whispered into the silence.

“He charged alone.”

Alone! Into the heart of the maelstrom, through fields of fire, weathering the spells of three Archmages and bombardment from all sides! The Goblin King advanced on the small army of mages, his forces struggling to come to his aid, his Goblin Lords scattered on the battlefield.

The Archmages of Wistram threw death towards him. They broke the earth and unleashed magics that burned the air itself. They struck him with lightning, they ensnared him with magical nets and the lesser [Mages] and [Archers] filled the skies with fireballs and arrows.

And yet the Goblin King came on. Velan the Kind charged ever onwards, his magical defenses slowly failing in front of the incredible assault. His flesh burned, the spells tore his body apart.

But still he came on. And here we come to one of the mysteries of the Second Antinium Wars, one of the places where history clearly diverged. Because of chance, dear readers. The Goblin King was approaching the first ranks of the mages, unstoppable. And one word separates this history from being a triumph to a tale of despair.

If.

If Velan the Kind had survived to rampage among the mages' ranks, the battle might have been lost despite the combined armies. His Goblin Lords had yet to begin falling, and the Archmages of Wistram might have well decided to flee rather than confront the Goblin King in person. And if they had, there was no guarantee of their survival, given how Velan had survived their most deadly spells at range. Had he lived, Velan might have gathered his forces and cut apart the allied armies, rallying his Goblins and dooming Izril.

But it was not to be. The Goblin King's charge that had crushed the finest of soldiers, gone through spell after spell and through an elite group of Gold-rank adventurers, stopped before it could cause disaster. And it was stopped by the simplest of things:

A single arrow through the eye.

It was incredible, unprecedented. The Goblin King's protections had been destroyed by the magical attacks on his person, but his body was still as tough as diamonds, his reflexes unhindered by the damage he had sustained. He was almost upon the first rank when a lone Silver-rank adventurer half-Elf by the name of Elia Arcsinger loosed an arrow that hit the Goblin King in the eye. She used the Skill [Piercing Shot] and at nearly point-blank range her arrow was able to do what every other arrow and spell could not. The lucky shot pierced the Goblin King's skull and killed him in an instant.

To this day, the death of Velan the Kind remains a contentious point among [Strategists] and [Tacticians] alike. Many argue that Velan the Kind should not have perished as he did, regardless of luck. While it is a known fact that a stray arrow or blade can kill all but the most well-defended warriors on the battlefield, many [Strategists] argue that the Goblin King should have been able to dodge the shot.

That the arrow was capable of killing the Goblin King was not in dispute. Elia Arcsinger was in possession of an enchanted Arrow of Slaying known for its piercing properties and was using a similarly enchanted longbow certified by several Gnoll [Bowmakers] as capable of propelling arrows as far as four hundred meters across the battlefield.

Combined with the [Piercing Shot] Skill, her arrow would have stood a good chance of piercing even the Goblin King's skin at point-blank range. That she struck him in the eye resulted in the fatal injury, all of which is understood to be accurate by most who take up this debate. The crux of the issue is that the Goblin King did not avoid the arrow, which most [Strategists] concede he should have been able to do.

The general argument is that the Goblin King had been known to catch arrows and dodge them in other battles. That he failed to do so in this case might have been due to the chaos of the battlefield, or the effects of one of the spells he endured. Nevertheless, there remains a vocal minority who claim that Elia Arcsinger used a special Skill or had some other enchantment on her body she herself may have been unaware of. Or perhaps her latest abilities were the reason for her miraculous shot.

After all, the half-Elf's fame for killing the Goblin King has resulted in Elia Arcsinger becoming known as one of the greatest Named Adventurers of this age. The title of Kingslayer and her famous [Line-End Shot] Skill obtained from killing the Goblin King do seem to indicate that the credit for

the Goblin King's death should lie with Elia Arcsinger and no other. And yet, many [Strategists] still argue the event to this day.

To this writer's mind there is little purpose speculating overlong as to the cause of the Goblin King's death. It is enough to say that he died, and the world will ever be grateful to Elia Arcsinger for her steady aim in that last hour of desperation. So let this bring an end to pointless debates. The Goblin King should have dodged. But he did not. And history will note that as fact. There is no point arguing over what occurred, especially when more important issues demand the attention of [Strategists] and their ilk.

"But that's so suspicious!"

Olesm leapt to his feet, tail thrashing as he forgot where he was and shouted in his small office. He angrily waved the book he was holding about, shouting at it as if his voice could reach Krsysl Wordsmith if only he was loud enough.

"That's the entire point! If the Goblin King should have survived, why didn't he? Was it a spell or a Skill or what? Was it betrayal like some theories indicate? Or did an Archmage cast a spell? What about the interview where Elia Arcsinger said herself she doesn't know why the Goblin King didn't dodge? Don't just gloss over all the important details, you egg-headed moron!"

He collapsed into his chair, panting, and held the book open.

"How did it happen? Why? Why did he die there when he should have won? Was it just luck? Really? Or was it something else?"

Olesm stared at the book, and turned the next page.

"This is a terrible historical account. I hope no one takes this seriously."

He read on, knowing what had happened next. What had happened, yes, but not the why. The why of it was lost to Olesm, a precious secret that no [Strategist] or [Archer] had even been able to puzzle out. Why didn't Velan the Kind dodge? What did he see? What happened?

Only the Goblins knew the truth. And even then, only a Goblin King could explain why it had happened. But it had. And that was that.

Or so the book said.

The battle finished minutes after the Goblin King's death. Although only a fraction of the Goblins present had witnessed the event, every Goblin on the field and perhaps every Goblin in the world sensed Velan the Kind die the moment it happened. Witnesses report seeing Goblins falling to their knees or throwing down their arms, allowing the combined armies to cut them down, too grief-stricken to fight back.

While it may be amusing to readers to imagine Goblins exhibiting any kind of grief, it does appear this was the case, as the Goblins fled, their morale broken by their King's demise. And with that, the last battle of the Second Antinium Wars was won. The Necromancer had been destroyed, the Goblin King slain, and the Antinium had been pacified. At least for the moment.

However, I would urge you good readers to consider this last warning—

The story ended. The Goblin King died on the pages as he had on the battlefield, and across the world, readers closed the book and looked up.

Some wept to hear of the Goblin King's death. The Goblins around the Goblin Lord bowed in grief, and with that grief harbored their terrible rage against the world. Others, like Tyrion, smiled and promised his sons the same truth in the world—that evil would always be vanquished and good triumph.

And some, like Erin and the Antinium, just closed the book and sat in silence for a while, absorbing this tale of what had been. It was a flawed history, true, but one with grains of truth. Those readers would sit in a moment of introspection, as time flowed strangely around them and they felt, just for a second, as if they could see the very fates that had led to that moment in history.

And then the moment would break and Erin would offer everyone popcorn with yeast, which was, as she claimed, the only way to eat popcorn. And the Antinium would eat and Klbkch would let Erin take over to tell another story—*Charlotte's Web*, a story which would cause much emotional distress on the part of every Soldier who had killed Shield Spiders.

Life went on, sometimes informed by the past, other times going on in blissful ignorance of it. Erin Solstice's attempts to comfort a Soldier and explain that Charlotte was a *special* spider would be entertaining if confusing, but that story was only a backdrop. The narrative had not ended yet, and one pair of readers continued on. They flipped the page and continued the history, reading the final notes of Krsysl Wordsmith.

However, I would urge you good readers to consider this last warning before closing this book. Yes, the war was over. The last of the Goblin Lords died as they hurled themselves into battle. Without their King, the Goblins fled, only to be cut down to the last Goblin by the victorious armies. The world was at peace again.

And yet, what a hard-won peace! And at such a cost! Velan the Kind's rampage might not have been as devastating as the last Goblin King's path of destruction across Terandria, but it was certainly catastrophic to the Humans. More importantly, the battles with the Necromancer, Antinium, and the Goblins had laid waste to the beloved Drake cities and would be the work of years rebuilding.

Unfortunately, that also meant the truce with the Antinium had to be honored. The allied armies declined to attack the Antinium despite the urging of many sensible minds. Foolishly, the various world leaders decided they were sick of war and let the Antinium remain a threat. Worse, they allowed the Antinium to establish a Hive in Liscor, one of the stipulations of the peace treaty!

Why the heroic people of Liscor allowed this is beyond this writer—indeed, the Liscorian army criticized and then resisted this move, leading to a rift between the public and army. Subsequently, the Liscorian army has rarely returned to its home city and spends much time on the campaign. A true shame.

But Liscor's problems are, alas, the world's problems. The Antinium are the one enemy side that survived the Second Antinium Wars, and their 'help' only highlights their threat as a group. Their victory was forestalled by the greater threats of the Goblin King and the Necromancer, but that does not erase their menace. They surprised us all with their advancements since the First Antinium War—I dread to think of what they might do if given time to prepare again.

It is my hope that this book will serve to warn readers of the Antinium and present them with a greater understanding of Drake sacrifices. We must stand together against the Antinium threat. Alone we are prey to menaces like the Goblins. Let this history be a record: the Antinium have been our enemies once, and our allies of convenience a second time. But they will

never be our friends. They remain our invaders and we must resist them. And it falls on the world to lend us their aid, lest the fall of the Drakes herald the death knell of the world.

We have survived Goblins, the undead, and the Antinium in this second great war for Izril. Let there never be another one in this writer's lifetime. But if there is, I, Krsysl Wordsmith will document the war and history to the best of my ability. History must not be forgotten and I will retell it as it should be again and again. Thank you for reading. I remain yours, most humbly,

–Krsysl Wordsmith

At last it was over. Zel Shivertail lowered the book and closed the cover slowly with one claw. Then he looked over at Lady Magnolia.

“What a terrible book. Why did you have me read through it again?”

She smiled sweetly at him and sipped from her cup of sugar and tea.

“Oh, perspective. My dear General Shivertail, don't tell me you object to such a glorious retelling of Drake history?”

Zel grunted. He felt like he should wash his claws after touching the book. He pushed it across the table towards Lady Magnolia.

“I do, actually. History should be impartial, not biased, and certainly not glorifying one species and insulting others. We all fought the Goblin King—to say any one species did more is insulting to all of us.”

“Ah, well, your opinions are not that of Mister Wordsmith's. I said as much to him when he first published the book, but I'm afraid he didn't listen to me. A pity you weren't there; I think he might have listened to a fellow Drake, let alone the famous Tidebreaker. I think he admires you.”

“Ancestors.”

The Drake [General] shuddered and shook his head. He was sitting in a tent—his personal tent—at the small table he’d requested. This wasn’t the command tent so he had little to look at, but he did have a smaller map of Invril and the surrounding landscape he was studying.

Lady Magnolia and her [Maid] Ressa were sitting in Zel’s tent as if there was nothing odd about them being there. They had dropped by unannounced earlier that evening and Lady Magnolia had forced the history book on Zel. He wished he’d refused.

“I heard about this book coming out. And I heard how widely it was criticized so I never bothered to pick it up. I understand quite a lot of copies were made—why would you ever fund something like this?”

“I? I wouldn’t put my name on this book if Krsysl Wordsmith paid *me*.”

Lady Magnolia’s eyebrows shot up. Zel glanced at her.

“I thought you funded this.”

“I funded the *first* history. Not the second.”

She corrected him. Lady Magnolia frowned and sighed as she put her tea cup on the table. She picked up the book and flipped through it sadly.

“I paid Krsysl Wordsmith to write the history of the First Antinium Wars shortly after it had ended. He was an eager young [Writer] and he did an excellent job of writing the history. It was widely praised as you know.”

“I do know. What went wrong with the second one?”

“The fame went to his head I fear. And he decided to take the money that had made him rich from writing the first book and invest it in the second. He wrote the second as a patriot, thinking it would make him beloved. Instead, it earned him criticism from his own people. Although he

does have quite a number of Drakes who still think of him as a good writer. I did try to persuade him to write a more unbiased history, but he detests me I'm afraid."

"That idiot."

Zel grunted. He picked up the book and shook his head as he flipped through pages of commentary, maps of the battlegrounds, sketches of the Goblin Lords—and one of himself. Zel stared at a rather flattering image of himself holding the Necromancer's head with Liscor in the background. He shook his head in disgust.

"This helps no one. The answer is simple and this author should have seen it. We have to fight together. That's how we beat the Goblin King. Peace between Humans and Drakes is more important than pride."

"Some would say that peace with the Antinium is just as important."

Lady Magnolia spoke cautiously, watching Zel. The [General] looked up.

"If you believed that, why invite me here? No, the Antinium don't believe in peace. And neither does the Necromancer."

"True. That is my view as well, which is why I have been preparing ever since the Second Antinium War ended. But some do say such things. And there is a...thought that the Antinium of Liscor might be less dangerous than the rest of their kind."

The Drake paused. He didn't know how Magnolia had heard that, but it didn't surprise him. He thought about Klbkch and his claws clenched into fists. But then he thought about Pawn and shook his head.

"Perhaps. I wouldn't know. But one Hive is far from all of them."

“Indeed. It is a thought though, and I want you to be aware of the opportunity that exists there. However, you are correct. The Grand Queen of the Antinium rules over her kind and she...bothers me. She will seize any opportunity she feels is right.”

“So will the Necromancer. I can’t believe he survived me ripping him apart.”

“Mm. Next time we’ll see about using a spell. I intend to make sure he is dead this time. But you can see why I haven’t pursued him yet.”

“Because he’s south of Liscor? A Drake problem?”

“Well, yes. Frankly, the problem is that both he *and* the Antinium are south of Liscor. Let’s assume the Drakes attacked one. The other would surely seize on that opportunity to force the Drakes into a war on two fronts.”

“Not a problem if we had Human help.”

“Indeed...but I am afraid that Human help might not turn up at all. Many Human [Lords] and [Ladies] would leave your people to fight alone, in the hopes of swooping in and defeating the victor. Or worse, your help might turn into a dagger in the back if Lord Tyrion were to march an army south of Liscor. He still dreams of conquering Izril, you know.”

“Wonderful. No wonder you wanted a Drake [General].”

Zel sighed. He felt old after hearing so much history. He had lived through most of it, true, but it felt like another lifetime. He was so old. He could still remember the First Antinium War. And the Second...Zel wondered if he’d live to see a third one. He didn’t want a third one, but what other choice was there?

A thought occurred to him as he pushed the book around on his table. Zel looked up at Magnolia with a frown.

“Where was your powerful magic-user ally during the Second Antinium War? Did he take part in the fighting at all? Or does he hail from another continent, like Niers Astoragon?”

Magnolia’s expression changed slightly. She pursed her lips together and looked slightly annoyed. She toyed with her teacup as she replied.

“He...excused himself from the war. The Goblins are not his enemy and he refused to battle them, much to my displeasure. He did succeed in stalling the Goblin King for a few days in the High Passes, though. I suppose that I owe him some credit for that.”

“Wonderful. So I can’t expect help against the Goblin Lord?”

“Do you need it?”

“I don’t know. Maybe. I’d like more certainty, but if I can’t have it then I’ll fight and see how it plays out.”

Zel stood up. He paced around his table, looking at the small map. So close. He’d plotted the Goblin Lord’s advance relative to his army. Magnolia Reinhart turned to face him. Her foot was jiggling just the slightest bit as she asked the question that had to be on everyone’s mind.

“How soon?”

“The day after tomorrow. Or tomorrow if he really marches his troops. He won’t, though. So it’s the day after tomorrow at some point. Day, night...I’ll force him into a day battle if I have to. I won’t let him play any tricks with the undead this time. It’ll be a straight-up battle.”

Zel Shivertail’s voice sounded loud in his ears. His heart pumped a little faster, thinking of it. So soon. But the Goblin Lord had turned towards Invrissil, against all expectations. He was coming here. And Zel was ready.

“I have given you all the tools at my disposal. We shall go over all of my estate’s resources tomorrow once more. If there is anything you need —”

Magnolia’s voice was brisk as she stood up. Zel turned his head and nodded absently at her.

“War Golems, that magical artifact...I’ve reviewed it all. I could use more adventurers if you can hire them.”

Magnolia pursed her lips.

“They don’t want to fight in a battle. This is technically not the defense of Invisil so I can’t conscript them easily. But I will double the reward for Gold-rank adventurers.”

She paused and looked at Zel.

“Are they so necessary?”

“Necessary? No. I think I can win this. Even without any adventurers. But I like stacking the odds in my favor. Call it the wisdom of age or something.”

Zel sighed. Magnolia stood next to him in silence for a few seconds.

“You will win, won’t you?”

“Probably. I don’t make promises before a battle. But yes, probably.”

“The Goblin Lord—”

“—Is not Velan the Kind. Your history book proves that. He’s a threat, a danger, and one I refuse to underestimate. But he’s no Goblin King.”

“Not yet.”

Magnolia’s words hung in the silence. Zel shook his head.

“Maybe not ever. A Goblin King is something rare. Something...I saw him during the final battle, you know. From a distance. I was on the front lines against his regular army. Holding the line. I saw him charging minutes before his death. And I thought he seemed so—so—”

“Dangerous? Strange? Frightening? Lonely?”

The Drake shook his head.

“Sad. As if he knew what was going to happen next.”

Magnolia stared at him. Ressa blinked. Zel turned away, embarrassed by the confession.

“It was just a feeling. But it stuck with me. And if that book you read taught me anything, it’s that we don’t know much about Goblins. Not truly. We don’t know why Velan ran berserk, why he died like he did...nothing. And this Goblin Lord is the same. We think he’s allied with the Necromancer, but is that as an equal, or as a servant?”

“Some questions have no answers. At least, none we can discern. I suspect the Goblin Lord is the only one who could answer your questions. Besides Az’kerash, at any rate.”

Zel nodded. His claws tightened on the book and he tossed it to one side. His head turned south, towards the coming battle. Soon. Tomorrow? The day after. Zel felt his heart beating faster. The Second Antinium War was over. The Goblin King was dead, but here was another Goblin Lord. Was he connected to the Necromancer?

“In that case, I’ll ask him when I have a claw around his throat.”

He turned and left the tent. Magnolia Reinhart’s gaze traced the same invisible line in the distance. She tapped a finger to her lips and whispered.

“We’ll see. Nothing is set in stone.”

Then she turned and kicked the book on the floor. Magnolia scowled at the book, rubbing at the tips of her toes and grimacing.

“I truly do hate history books. Honestly, I think I’ll hire a Gnoll to write the next one.”

She stomped out of the tent, leaving *The Second Antinium Wars, a History* lying on the ground. After a moment Ressa picked it up and followed her mistress and Zel Shivertail outside. The stage was set, the pieces all in place. It was time for another page in the story of the world to begin.

Soon.

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Time was peculiar. Lady Magnolia knew that well. Some days, some moments could seem to last forever while entire years could flash by. It was all a matter of how much was happening. When it seemed like the world was ending and dire news was the headline of each morning, time could be at a standstill as every day became an unfolding disaster. By the same token, though, when there was too much to do and time was precious, it slipped away like shadows in the sun.

She planned with Zel Shivertail, letting the [General] take command of his forces, assisting where she could without getting in the way. Magnolia pulled strings, marshalled all the resources at her immediate disposal, flattened gossip in places and encouraged it in others, and heard reports from [Scouts]. A day passed like that and then it was time.

The Goblins were here.

The first sign of their presence was the distant drum beats that echoed across the grasslands like thunder. The last of the winter's cold fled with their arrival, and the dark skies and overcast day heralded a wet, if temperate battlefield.

“Muddy. Bad footing. I wish we could have had better weather for today's battle.”

Magnolia Reinhart turned her head as she stood on those same fields. She had been staring at a black mass in the distance. Now she looked at an armored woman by her side. The woman was dressed so she looked nothing like the [Maid] she was—wearing thick metal armor and carrying an enchanted mace, she was the spitting image of Odveig, the former leader of

the Celestial Trackers. But Sacra had many disguises, many faces. And Magnolia appreciated the depth of her knowledge in moments like these.

“Why is mud disadvantageous, Sacra? Aside from the obvious reasons. I would assume that the danger of slipping applies to Goblins as equally as Humans.”

Sacra bowed her head slightly, not taking her eyes off of the distant Goblin host.

“Your pardon Lady Reinhart. But Goblins are experienced in fighting in almost all forms of weather and terrain. Humans are not. Some of the soldiers here won’t have practiced in these conditions. They’ll be at a slight disadvantage.”

“I see. Hopefully General Shivertail will be able to compensate.”

Magnolia turned her gaze back towards the Goblins. They had been marching steadily towards Invril for two hours now, across the plains outside of Invril. The Human army had decided to meet them four miles outside of Invril’s suburbs. Any closer and the Goblins might use the houses and buildings as cover, or worse, scale the outermost walls and threaten the city itself.

Invril had not come under attack since the Second Antinium Wars. It had grown without fear, safe from [Bandits] and monsters due to the high number of adventurers who lived within its confines. But now, in the face of the Goblin Lord’s armies, those same adventurers were in hiding.

All but a few. Magnolia shifted her gaze and stared at the army of Humans that had formed up ahead of her, in the path of the approaching army. The armor of thousands of [Soldiers] gleamed in the light drizzle from overhead, and Magnolia could see hundreds, maybe thousands of banners, each proclaiming a unit from a different village, town or city.

Just over forty thousand soldiers. A vast army. And yet the Goblin Lord's forces were reported to be almost double that number. True, his forces would be comprised of noncombatants as well, children, pregnant Goblins, the elderly...and a good half of his army was the undead horde.

Even so, the numbers alone made Magnolia's heart beat quicker. She stared at the Goblins until another voice spoke up.

"It's not right."

"What is?"

Lady Bethal stared at the Goblin Lord's army. It was spreading out across the grasslands, growing larger by the second. So many. Magnolia tried to count and gave up. Bethal's voice was pained, the only sound in the silence.

"We should have brought twice as many soldiers to this battlefield. Three times. These are *Goblins*. Why hasn't every city within a thousand miles turned out their garrisons to support us? This isn't a matter of politics! Why are we so divided? But instead Lord Tyrion siphons off soldiers we need, and so we have to send a Drake legend in with a half-formed army—"

"I know."

Magnolia cut her friend off. She sighed.

"I know, Bethal. But we Humans do not always act in the best interests of our people. We are selfish, paranoid, petty...I should have known my enemies would fight me, even in this. They would let a city of hundreds of thousands burn to hurt me."

"Fools."

"Not fools. Not entirely. Just...uncaring, I think. To his credit, Zel Shivertail realized how lackluster a force he had been given. But he chose

to lead it anyway. He thinks he can win, not just defend, Bethal.”

Magnolia stared out across the ranks of Human soldiers, at the lone figure standing on the front lines. Zel Shivertail’s armor glowed in the dim light, a beacon for all those who looked for such things. Bethal shook her head.

“I pray he’s right, Magnolia. My Thomast is out there and almost all of my Knights of the Petal. If they are lost—”

Her eyes flicked to her husband, lost in the sea of soldiers. Magnolia could spot the iconic [Knights] in their light pink and red armor. She tried to soothe Bethal, although she didn’t feel that calm herself.

“Your husband is quite competent, Bethal. As for your [Knights]—they are the most elite force on the field, bar none. We must commit all we can to this battle. And remember, if you should see Thomast in trouble, you have given me your word *not* to go into the battle.”

“I know.”

Bethal sighed loudly and Magnolia eyed her. That had been the condition she’d imposed on Bethal before she’d let the other [Lady] observe the battle. Magnolia and her small retinue stood at a distance from the army and battlefield itself. Close enough to observe, but far enough in theory that the Goblin Lord would not trouble himself with them. And if he did...

Sacra stood with both feet planted on the ground, mace by her side. She was joined by eighteen other [Maids] and [Servants]...none of whom were wearing their usual uniforms today. They were all former spellcasters and warriors and they were all armed with magical artifacts.

A small guard. Magnolia had put her faith in Zel Shivertail. She wasn’t here to fight herself; she was an observer in this battle. Well, an observer with a small role to play. Magnolia’s gaze flicked to the two huge covered

wagons parked by her small escort. Both lacked mounts to pull them anywhere and were sinking slightly into the ground at the moment. Each one was large enough to hold several horses if you managed to get them up into such a confined space, and they were large enough to take shelter behind.

But again, if it came to that then something had gone wrong. Magnolia trusted Zel Shivertail to win this battle. And as if her thoughts had summoned him, she saw his figure heading her way.

Zel Shivertail rode a horse briskly towards Magnolia and her escort, and Magnolia walked forwards to meet him. She had been only vaguely surprised to learn Zel Shivertail was a competent rider—he never rode horses when fighting, so it was rare that he got a chance to show off his skills.

“Is there something wrong?”

“No. I’m changing the plan, though. Hold the secret weapons until the Goblin Lord makes his move. Don’t unleash them unless you think you have a shot at him.”

“Why, pray tell? They could cause extensive damage—”

Magnolia bit her tongue as she realized she was asking questions of a [General]. *She* was no [General]; she should just let him do his work. Zel answered her curtly as he eyed the distant Goblin Lord’s army.

“I don’t like the looks of the Goblin Lord’s vanguard. I took a look at them with a spyglass—it seems like he has a very strong escort and he’s entrenched himself in his army. It will be hard to get a clear shot at him unless it’s by surprise.”

“I understand. I will wait for the opportunity, then.”

Magnolia smoothed her skirts, glad the magical fabric couldn't get dirty or wet. She looked at the Drake [General] and couldn't help but ask a few more questions.

“Do you believe you're prepared? There are still a few more contingency measures we could take. The magical artifact my grandfather gave me—”

“That thing?”

Zel turned his head and eyed the strange tube-like object that Magnolia had brought with her. It was resting on a small pedestal, guarded by two of her [Maids]. He shook his head.

“Unless the battle turns badly, don't use it. I'd rather save that for the Great Chieftain you were talking about. And I'd rather not risk collateral damage since we don't know exactly what it does.”

“Very well. And I see you have equipped the artifacts I gave you. Excellent.”

Zel frowned as he scratched at the pair of rings on his fingers. Magnolia knew he also had a pendant around his neck. They seemed to be annoying the Drake.

“Yes. I'm grateful, really, but I don't like rings. I fight with my claws, you know. These things can catch when I hit something.”

Magnolia pursed her lips, unsympathetic.

“I should imagine their effects outweigh whatever awkwardness you feel, General. They will protect you from unfortunate teleportation, curses, mental attack spells...they should be standard fare to someone of your rank. I can't understand how you survived this long without them!”

“Probably because everyone thought I had them on and never bothered to test whether I had them or not. And I’ve survived nasty spells before. One time I got teleported off of a cliff...”

Zel grunted. His eyes were going back to the Goblin army. They were coming so *slowly*. Magnolia tried to keep her voice light and bantering. She and Zel were both icons after all. They had to pretend to be calm for the sake of others.

“I suppose Drakes don’t bother with magical protections, then? You, what, trust the strength of your scales?”

“Hardly. You should see some of them. I know a Lord of the Wall that has rings on every finger. No, I was never supported by the Walled Cities so I had to make do without. And any artifacts I used I returned. Well, I’ll try to get these back to you in one piece.”

“Please, consider them a gift. It would hardly do for me to be seen as stingy and I have quite a few ugly rings in my collection.”

“Thank you.”

They traded words like that for a few more minutes, both keeping their eyes on the Goblin Lord’s army. And then Zel nodded towards the black host in the distance.

“It’s time. Remember what I said. Wait for the Goblin Lord to be exposed. And as for the rest...”

He paused. Magnolia waited, her heart beating fast, her face composed. Zel Shivertail just shrugged.

“It’s time.”

“Fortune in battle!”

Magnolia called after Zel's back as he turned his horse. She heard Sacra and the others around her saying something similar. Magnolia shook her head. Such old sayings. Such trite words. As if that would help one whit.

This was a battle. And as the Goblins came close enough for Magnolia to see their faces in the distance, she heard the drum beats striking louder now, the thumping in rhythm with her chest.

Doom. Doom.

The sound was like the steps of a giant. Only this giant was made of tens of thousands of black-armored Goblins, hordes of shambling undead. Magnolia stared across the ranks of Human swordsmen, mounted riders, archers, nervously staring at their foe. She wondered how they could look at that massive army and not run. There were so many! But the Humans were numerous too. The Goblins approached, spreading out like a breaking wave. Closer, closer—

And then the drumbeats ceased. Magnolia's heart skipped a beat as the absence of sound affected her more powerfully than the noise. She stared at the Goblins and then saw him.

A Goblin sitting on a massive Shield Spider. A figure dressed in robes. He didn't shine with an aura or radiate malice, but there was no mistaking him. The Goblin Lord rode his mount to the head of his army and raised his hand.

"Sacra, what is he—"

Magnolia turned to Sacra, about to ask her opinion. Without Ressa she was acting as commentator and analyst of the battle. But she never got a chance to voice her question. Because as the Goblin Lord raised his hand the Goblins around him raised their weapons and shouted one word.

“Goblin.”

The noise broke the silence and rippled across the plains, causing a physical shift in the army of Humans. Magnolia’s ears rang and she saw the servants around her wince. Only Sacra, Bethal, and Magnolia didn’t flinch.

The effect on the Human army was just as effective. Magnolia could see ranks of [Soldiers] waver for a second before standing straight. Just one word had caused their morale to waver.

And it wasn’t over. The Goblin Lord raised his hand again and the Goblins shouted.

“Goblin!”

The noise was fury and bloodshed, monstrous, the very definitions of what Goblins could be. Magnolia calmed herself with a Skill, looking across her army. They weren’t breaking, but the Human soldiers were clearly unnerved by the sound.

“He’s trying to shatter our morale!”

Sacra shouted at Magnolia, explaining the obvious. Magnolia nodded, noting that Sacra had taken the mace from her belt. Again, the Goblin Lord raised his hand and the sound rolled forth.

“Goblin!”

Again the massed voices of the Goblins struck the Humans. Magnolia had to admire the simplicity of it. It was like being attacked, but there was no way to fight back. A few of the Human officers tried to raise their own cheers, and Magnolia heard the cries taken up, but only by a small

percentage of the army. And the wavering voices made the Goblins' earth-shattering chant all the more terrifying.

“Idiots. You can't beat Goblins in a shouting contest.”

Sacra shook her head as she twirled the mace in her hands, eyeing the Goblin army restlessly. Magnolia raised her voice to be heard.

“How do you do it, then?”

“What?”

“How do you beat them?”

“Like that!”

Sacra pointed. Magnolia stared until she saw the lone figure standing at the head of the Human army. Zel Shivertail. He had advanced a few paces ahead of the front rank of swords and pikes so he was visible to most of his army. He stood, his armor shining, arms folded as the Goblins shouted again.

“*Goblin!*”

They had spotted him, Humans and Goblins alike. The Goblins were screaming, their noise filling the air and the Humans were shouting too. They wanted Zel to raise his hands, to fight sound with sound. But Zel did nothing.

He just stood. Waiting. And as Magnolia watched the Goblin Lord exalting his army again, she realized what Sacra meant.

The Goblins roared at him, screaming, tens of thousands of Goblin voices howling their rage and fury. And still, Zel stood with arms folded. Waiting. And as they screamed, the Goblins stared at him. And their voices began to falter.

They all knew him. Foolishly, the Goblin Lord had studied Zel Shivertail, had read his stories. Tidebreaker, [General of the Line], hero of two Antinium Wars. The greatest [General] of the Drakes. And so rumors had spread. Zel Shivertail had trickled into the Goblin consciousness like poison. And now he was here, and that knowledge was magnified by his presence.

Zel Shivertail was *huge*. It wasn't just his physical appearance, which was already imposing. He was like a giant shrunken down and contained within a much smaller body. He dominated the attention of the battlefield.

And he stood there, listening to the Goblins cheering, staring at the Goblin Lord. Just stood. But as Magnolia stared at his back she felt the apprehension from the Goblins' chanting vanish. The Humans standing behind Zel stood straighter. His armor shone like fire and Zel waited.

Slowly, the Goblin chanting stopped. They stared at Zel, frustrated, angry, and perhaps, afraid. Because of what he was. What he represented.

There stood one who had fought the Goblin King, had fought his Goblin Lords. He was *right there*. And he was terrifying.

The silence had regained the battlefield. Magnolia saw the Goblin Lord waving his hands, shouting, frustration clear in his motions as the Goblins advanced again. By her side, Sacra nodded approvingly.

"We might not have won the battle of morale, but we certainly didn't lose."

"And now it begins."

Bethal stared at the Goblins as they began to march rapidly on the Human army. Magnolia waited, her heart beating loudly, her eyes scanning the battlefield. She realized that the waiting, the chanting, all of it, had just

been the most basic of preludes. The battle began in earnest as the Goblins streamed towards the Humans, shouting, marching in black ranks.

The arrows came first. Magnolia saw a company of [Archers] led by one of the few Gold-rank adventurers raise their bows. The highest-level [Markswomen] and [Snipers] among them had the Skills and enchanted weapons to fire across hundreds of feet, and they began loosing arrows into the front rank of Goblins. Black bodies tumbled downwards, just a handful, and the Goblins raised their shields higher, snarling and trampling over their fallen.

And they had archers of their own. Magnolia saw arrows flying back towards the Human army—just a few at first, but more and more as the two armies closed in distance. The Gold-rank adventurer in the archer's group—a Gnoll woman with a longbow—dodged as an arrow shot towards her head. She nocked an arrow and loosed it—Magnolia saw the Goblin who'd aimed at her fall, clawing at an arrow in his chest.

The duel between archers halted abruptly as the Goblins came within a hundred feet. Now Magnolia heard [Captains] calling out orders.

“Hold! Draw! Wait for it—*loose!*”

A rain of deadly projectiles shot across the muddy ground towards the front rank of Goblins. Several fell, but the black armor the Goblins wore shielded them from the worst of it, as did their shields. They were coming faster now. The Goblin Lord pointed and his voice snapped an order. The front rank of Goblins surged towards the Human army.

And now Magnolia could see the Hobs. A line of over a hundred of them charged towards Zel Shivertail and his army, giant green warriors coated in black armor, holding massive weapons and roaring as they came. The Human [Archers] were aiming at them, trying to bring them down, but for every one they felled, ten more came on.

“Dead gods. They’re going to be overrun!”

Bethal stared at the front rank. The Humans there were low-level. They weren’t [Lineholders] or experienced warriors! Hobs were a Silver-rank threat! Magnolia watched as well. She bit her lip and whispered.

“Come now, General Shivertail. Tell me you know how to deal with this.”

“Oh, dead gods.”

Lieutenant Gershal of Vaunt felt his heart stop as he saw the Goblins charging. He had been assigned to the front ranks with his unit and had lamented the fact with the other sympathetic officers. But he hadn’t realized what it meant until this moment.

A wave of Goblins was coming at him, as endless as the sea. And at the head of them—

Hobgoblins. The closest one was a head taller than Gershal and three times as wide. Gershal could see the flecks of spit, see the frenzied crimson eyes staring at him, the gigantic maul in the Goblin’s hands—

“Steady.”

A voice snapped Gershal out of his trance. He looked to one side and saw another officer, the [Captain] assigned to the area, speaking to him. Gershal realized he’d taken a step back. The soldiers around him were doing the same. Horrified, Gershal realized the entire front was pulling back in face of the Goblins’ charge. He shouted at his men, ashamed and terrified.

“Hold your positions! Hold, damn your cheese-rotted heads!”

Cheese-rotted heads. It was a petty insult children used in Vaunt. But it worked. The soldiers jumped and half-looked towards Gershal before snapping out of their fear. They reformed the line, men and women holding shields, pikes trained on the Goblins, swords ready for when they broke past the pikes.

Gershal carried a sword and shield as well. He breathed heavily, his eyes on the Drake in shining armor ahead of him. If he stared at Zel Shivertail he could hold his ground. But the *Hobs*! They were seconds away. What was going to happen when they hit? They’d be swept away, all of them!

Zel Shivertail hadn’t moved in the face of the Goblins’ charge. Now, as they were about to hit the front line, he shifted. He raised one claw and spoke. Gershal barely heard his voice over the roar of the Goblins.

“[Stonewall Formation]. [Chargebreaker Guard].”

Something filled Gershal and he gasped as his shield felt warm. His footing on the slippery mud and grass felt firmer. But he couldn’t analyze the feeling. The Goblins hit his line and the entire army in a roar and crash of metal on metal that dwarfed every sound Gershal had heard in his life.

The first wave of Goblins *smashed* into the soldiers around Gershal. He saw a gigantic Hob charging towards him. The [Lieutenant] raised his shield, heart pounding. The Hob had a massive hammer and swung towards Gershal. It was too late to dodge, but Gershal knew he’d never block the blow. He *braced*—

And the hammer glanced off his shield. Gershal gaped and the Hob staggered. Gershal stumbled back. The blow had been incredibly strong, but it hadn’t smashed through his iron and wood shield! Both Human and Goblin were so surprised that they stared at each other for a moment.

And then instinct took over. Gershal swung his sword desperately as the Hob raised his hammer. His sword glanced off the Hob's gauntleted arm and again the hammer came down! And again, it was blocked.

Gershal staggered under the force of the blow. It was tremendous! He could feel the incredible impact, and yet his shield and body held. No—more than that! With *one arm* he thrust the hammer away and the Hob stumbled backwards. Gershal charged into the Hob, screaming, and thrust his sword towards the gap between his chest plate and leg armor.

The Hob howled as Gershal's blade struck him in the thigh, glancing off bone. He swung his hammer and Gershal darted back. The two traded blows, and again, Gershal found his shield could handle each of the Hob's devastating attacks! But the Hob was quick and powerful. He blocked each of Gershal's thrusts, snarling, trying to strike around Gershal's shield with his slower weapon.

So caught up were the two in their duel that neither one realized where they were. Gershal backed up from the Hob's swing and collided with something from behind. He turned—

And another Hob twisted around, her axe covered with blood. This Hob was taller than both Gershal and the hammer-wielding Hob. She was standing over a Human soldier, or what remained of them. The pike in their hands had been hacked in two from the Hob's blows. Now both Hobs closed in on Gershal from either side.

He jabbed at them with his sword, trying to back up. But the Hobs were fearless. The female Hob swung her axe and only Gershal's shield saved his head from being split open. The hammer-wielding Hob charged, roaring, his weapon aimed at Gershal's back—

And a flash of green charged into him. Gershal spun and saw the Hob falling. Gershal stared.

The Hob was falling to the ground. His black armor, impervious to Gershal's iron sword, was torn open and his chest was a bloody mass. And standing over him was a Drake in shining armor.

Zel Shivertail.

Gershal stared. He heard the female Hob scream and Zel turned. The Drake *caught* the blade of the axe as it swung towards his face and his left hand slashed across the female Hob's chest. His claws were long and cut through the Hob's armor like it wasn't there. Gershal stared as the female Hob sagged. Zel dropped her and turned towards Gershal.

"You're out of line! Get back!"

He roared and Gershal thought he was reprimanding him for a second. Then he realized—he *was* out of line! His duel with the Hob had carried him out of the line of Human soldiers and into the Goblin army. He backed up as Goblin soldiers streamed forwards around him, jabbing at him with spears, swinging swords he barely blocked with his armor and shield—

Zel Shivertail turned. He *kicked* a Goblin into eight of his friends, so hard the black metal bent and the Goblin screamed, and then slashed with his claws. *Left, right, left!* Each time a Goblin fell, their armor rent and torn open by Zel's claws. He caught their weapons with his bare hands, impervious to the cutting edges and cleared a space around him, cutting down Goblins while Gershal found his unit.

"Hold your ground!"

The Drake roared as the Humans pushed back the first line of Goblins. He turned and charged towards a Hob—seconds later the Hob was dead and Zel was finding his next target. The Human [Soldiers] and Gershal himself roared in response to their [General]'s heroics. Gershal felt like his arm was ablaze with energy—he blocked a Goblin's thrust as if it was nothing and cut the Goblin down, shouting. They could win this! They could win!

And then the arrows came and more Goblins. Gershal held the line with his soldiers, fighting, falling, dragging wounded friends to safety while more [Soldiers] rushed forwards to fill the gaps.

That was the first five minutes of the battle.

“It’s working! They’re doing it!”

Bethal clutched at Magnolia, shaking her shoulder as they watched the battle from afar. Magnolia endured the shaking. She was a [Lady] and she couldn’t display an undignified countenance.

Of course, Bethal was a [Lady] as well, but they were quite, quite different. Magnolia eventually got Bethal to let go by grabbing her hands.

“I see that Bethal. Sacra, it looks like the Goblin charge has failed.”

“For now.”

Sacra eyed the Goblins as they clashed with the front rank of Humans, led by Zel. It was a slaughter on both sides, but one that was definitely favoring the Humans. They were holding, reinforcing gaps in their lines while their soldiers cut down wave after wave of the Goblins. The Goblin Lord’s Hobs, his elite shock troopers that gave him an advantage over the Human soldiers, were being stalemated by Zel’s defensive Skills.

But that was only the beginning of the battle. Magnolia saw the mass of Goblins that had crashed against Zel’s front line moving left and right, trying to flank the Humans. Correspondingly, battalions of Human soldiers were racing across the ground.

“We don’t have the numbers to keep spreading out like this, surely?”

Magnolia pointed the extending front line out to Sacra, worried. The Goblins were racing to encircle Zel's army. Sacra shook her head.

"We don't have to. Look—we're holding them off across this line while our archers hit them. Our mages are slowing their advance—"

Fireballs and lightning were blasting ranks of Goblins apart where they clustered most heavily. The Goblins were answering in kind—Magnolia saw flashes of magic blasting into Human soldiers, shards of ice splintering off shields, and acidic splashes causing some to drop their weapons and claw at their faces.

"—And our cavalry's moving. If the Goblin Lord splits his forces too far trying to encircle us—yes, there they go!"

Magnolia followed Sacra's gaze and saw a wedge of mounted Humans smash into a section of the Goblin line where they'd extended themselves too far. She saw the mounted riders hacking their way through, cutting off that group of Goblins from their main army. Surrounded, the Goblins quickly succumbed to the encircling Humans as the riders broke away.

"That's right! Hit them and away! On me!"

Captain Salvia laughed and shouted as her [Riders] cut into the Goblins. She raised her sword and whirled it, spraying Goblin blood. At once, the mounted warriors under her command wheeled their horses. The Goblins were already surging after them, loosing arrows and trying to catch her soldiers. Salvia grimaced as she saw an arrow pierce a horse's side and both animal and rider went down. The Goblins on foot charged the fallen soldier, intent on tearing him to shreds.

Not yet. She galloped past the man and caught his outstretched hand. Her own stallion slowed as Salvia pulled the man into her saddle. She patted him and prayed he could hold their weight. Just a little further!

“Break away! Back to the lines! Move it, move it!”

Her soldiers streamed away too quickly for the Goblins to catch. Salvia let the horseless man drop as soon as they were close to their lines—he sprinted towards the back where more warhorses were ready to go. She turned her mount, listening for the next order from General Shivertail or a [Strategist].

The Goblins were floundering, surprised by their inability to break the Human front line, unprepared for the lightning-fast attacks. Their own spider riders were too slow to catch up with the Humans and that meant they were prey to Salvia’s forces. She grinned, her heart still pumping fast in her chest.

“This is the way to fight a battle! Come on lads, let’s hit the Goblins again!”

She spotted an opening—a gap in the Goblin lines at the same time a [Messenger] rode towards her, pointing and shouting. Salvia kicked her horse into a gallop and she rode towards the break, her soldiers screaming war cries behind her. She hoped Gershal and his cheese-eating lot were alright. But then the battle overtook her and Salvia’s only thoughts were to cut and block and turn her mount.

They were winning! At least—for the moment.

“Too fast!”

Goblins. Osthia Blackwing was chained and muzzled as she stood by the Goblin Lord's personal guard. He'd dragged her onto the battlefield although she'd fought her captors. She wasn't sure if it was a blessing or curse; he was using her as a tool to gauge the enemy's tactics. Now she watched as the Goblin Lord gave rapid orders, trying to overtake Zel Shivertail's forces and hammer them from all sides.

She'd watched his disastrous first charge with grim satisfaction. The Goblin Lord had known Zel Shivertail was a defensive [General], but hearing that and seeing a *Hob* being bested by a low-level [Soldier] with a shield and spear was something else entirely. Now the Goblin Lord was raging as the Human cavalry stymied his force's advance.

"Move! Order undead—there!"

He pointed and a ripple went through the Goblins around him. Goblin [Necromancers] and [Shamans] began pointing and chanting and Osthia saw the undead horde move at last.

Tens of thousands of zombies, some halfway towards skeletons themselves, lurched into motion. They'd been circling the Human army, ignoring the arrows and spells that had cut down their number by the hundreds with each passing minute, and now they advanced on the Humans from the left.

Slowly. Only a few of the zombies were 'fresh' enough to run, and only the Goblin Lord could make them do that. A few hundred Ghouls raced out of the ranks of undead and surged towards a group of Humans who'd formed a line to meet them.

The Ghouls lunged into the ranks of Humans, tearing, biting with unnatural speed. They were outnumbered and quickly dispatched, but they'd dragged down quite a number of soldiers before they fell. And they

were just the first wave. The zombies met the Humans and died as the soldiers sliced the slower undead apart.

But a second wave was already crawling over the first, grabbing at shields and advancing despite being speared through the chest. They threatened to overwhelm the Humans by sheer numbers, and Osthia saw a giant Crypt Lord belching bile over a group of Humans, making them vomit and fall to the ground—

“Good! Now. Break lines.”

The Goblin Lord was pushing on two fronts. The undead were now threatening Zel Shivertail’s left and he had to pull his forces back. [Archers] and [Mages] began hitting the undead, easing up pressure on the Goblins from the front. Osthia saw the Humans begin to struggle a bit as they fought the Goblins without support. Still, Zel’s Skills were holding the ground and creating a wall of steel the Goblins struggled to break. If that was all—

A Hob was on the front lines, fighting a knot of Humans with pikes. He was unable to break their shields with his large club despite his massive strength, and as Osthia watched a pike pierced the crude black iron armor on his chest. He stumbled backwards, mortally wounded.

The Hob stared at the blood gushing from the wound on his chest and looked up. His eyes flickered—he reached behind him and grabbed something. Osthia saw the Hob lift a small figure onto his back and charged the pikes, roaring.

They speared him halfway. The Hob sagged and Osthia saw the Humans cheering. But that small figure on the Hob’s back was moving. It slipped from his body and stumbled towards the Humans. Osthia saw a Human with a sword turn, puzzled by the tiny Goblin. She shouted, her words lost by distance and the leather restraining her mouth.

No! But it was too late. The Human impaled the Goblin with his sword. No, not the Goblin. The Goblin *child*. The *undead* Goblin child.

The undead Goblin exploded. Osthia heard the roar of the blast from her position near the Goblin Lord. She had to look away as the explosion engulfed the Humans and nearby Goblins—when she could see again the entire group of Humans was gone and Goblins were flooding into the gaps.

Exploding undead. The Goblin Lord's secret weapon, courtesy of Az'kerash. Osthia turned her head and stared at the Goblin Lord with pure hatred. She saw the Goblin Lord facing towards the site of the blast, claws clenched into fists.

His hands were *bleeding*. Osthia stared as his claws dug into his flesh, red rivulets of blood dripping down his hands. The Goblin Lord turned, and the pain and fury in his gaze found her. He stared at Osthia for a second and then pointed. His voice was cold.

“Destroy the front lines.”

Osthia turned and saw more explosions. The undead Goblin children were slipping through the ranks of struggling Goblins and Humans and detonating themselves. They destroyed the Humans' lines, turning them into chaotic battles as Goblins capitalized on the broken formations and charged ahead. Osthia shifted in silent despair.

The exploding undead! Zel Shivertail had known about this, surely! He had to have heard the reports—but how could you deal with such a tactic? He couldn't just retreat, and yet each time the Goblins detonated, his army was thrown into disarray! She saw Zel Shivertail turning, shouting orders as the Humans scattered to reform their lines. And then she saw the first pink [Knight] striding forwards.

“What is that?”

The Goblin Lord's eyes narrowed as he spotted the first Rose Knight. The armored warrior stepped into place where a Goblin child had detonated. The Goblins were charging into the gap, trying to fill the space before the Humans could replenish their ranks. They ran at the pink knight as he raised a halberd. The [Knight] swung—

And a row of Goblins disappeared in a blaze of flames. Osthia's eyes widened and the Goblin Lord sat up on his mount. The Rose Knight twirled his halberd and stabbed—flames shot from the blade and burned through a group of Goblins, making them scream and roll on the ground to quench the magical flames. The [Knight] calmly held his ground as regular Human [Soldiers] pushed forwards, resetting their lines.

And across the battlefield, more Rose Knights were on the front. They stood on the front, calmly cutting down the Goblins. Holding the line. Osthia saw one Rose Knight strike down a Goblin and then crush an undead Goblin with his foot. He vanished in an explosion, but when the smoke cleared he was getting back on his feet, stunned, but still alive.

“Pink-armored warriors too strong! Cannot kill!”

The Goblin Lord snarled as a Goblin cried out. He narrowed his eyes as a group of Human [Archers] began sniping at the explosive undead Goblins scattered in his ranks. One shot took an undead Goblin through the throat—the blast eradicated a pair of Hobs and a group of Goblins in the back lines of his army.

“No more undead! Move to left!”

He pointed, and Osthia saw the undead children lurching away, joining the mass of undead. Osthia grinned. His tactics were failing. The Goblin Lord stared at the Rose Knight with the halberd. He was cutting down a Hob, unscathed, his armor painted red with Goblin blood. The Goblin Lord made a sound of outrage. Then he stood up and pointed.

“[Deathbolt].”

Magnolia was listening to the cheering from the Human army when she saw the black bolt of magic fly across the battlefield and strike the Rose Knight in the chest. She saw the armored man stumble as the magic splashed across his armor, almost like a liquid. He raised his halberd and struck down a nearby Goblin, but his movements were palpably slower. And the Goblin Lord wasn't done. He pointed and another black bolt flew across the battlefield.

This time the Rose Knight tried to dodge. But a group of Goblins surrounded him and seized him, weighing him down. The black magic struck the Rose Knight twice more in the chest, splashing across the pink armor in quick succession. The [Knight] wavered, stumbled, and as the third spell struck his head he collapsed.

“No!”

Bethal stared in horror as one of her elite [Knights] fell, struck dead by the Goblin Lord's magic. The Goblins swarmed over his body, cheering, seizing his halberd and using it against the Humans around him.

“Sacra, what was that?”

Magnolia snapped at Sacra. The [Maid] shook her head.

“I know what that was.”

A voice spoke up. The three women turned and saw Reynold, dismounting from Magnolia's pink carriage. He was breathless—he must have just arrived because the tracks in the mud were still oozing back into place.

“Reynold, do you know—”

“One company of Gold-rank adventurers, the Fire Fingers and a Silver-rank team, Embryon’s Delight, agreed to your terms Lady Reinhart. I just dropped them off. They’re fighting the undead.”

Reynold pointed and Magnolia saw a group of Dwarves and [Mages] fighting their way into the undead from the left. She nodded in approval. A few adventurers had been enticed by her offers and Magnolia had quadrupled the gold reward in the last hour. Reynold had been assigned to deliver whomever was willing to fight to the battlefield.

“Thank you, Reynold. Now, what happened to Lady Bethal’s knight?”

“Sir Evimore.”

Bethal whispered through pale lips. Reynold clenched his jaw grimly.

“I’ve seen that spell before. It’s death magic. The Necromancer used a similar one. It’s instant death to anyone below Level 20. That might not be the same spell—maybe a weaker one, but it’s powerful enough. Look, he’s going to continue casting.”

The [Butler]’s face was grave as he pointed. The Goblin Lord was drinking from a bottle and as he downed the last dregs of the mana potion one of the [Archers] shot an arrow at him. The arrow *swerved* as it neared the Goblin Lord and bounced off his Shield Spider’s carapace. The Goblin Lord turned his head and casually pointed a finger. The black magic shot across the battlefield and the archer and four of his fellows fell over, dead in an instant.

“He’s taking out our high-level soldiers!”

Magnolia exclaimed in horror. The Goblin Lord was casting the [Deathbolt] spell rapidly now, and another Rose Knight found himself under attack. The armored woman was forced to dodge the black magic,

which left her open to a Hob. He smashed her across the head with a glowing mace and her helmet bowed in slightly. The Rose Knight stumbled, another [Deathbolt] hit her from the side, and she fell.

“Why isn’t that armor working! I thought it was supposed to *protect* those knights from practically anything!”

Magnolia turned to Lady Bethal. The [Lady] shook her head. Her face was white as another of her prized [Knights] fell, the second in minutes.

“There’s no armor in the world that will protect against every kind of magic. Magnolia, tell that Drake to pull my knights back before they’re slaughtered!”

She grabbed Magnolia, pointing to Zel as the [General] turned, seeing the effects the Goblin Lord’s magic was having on the battlefield. Magnolia shook her head.

“I am in no position to tell Zel Shivertail anything. He must see the issue—yes, look!”

The Rose Knights were retreating from the front. Faced with this separate threat they were regrouping. A wall of forty or so took up positions on the right flank of the battlefield and Magnolia saw the Goblins backing up *fast* rather than charge their position. The Goblin Lord pointed and another [Deathbolt] flew, but this time it failed to strike down a Rose Knight.

One of the armored pink knights raised his shield and the magic burst against the shield. He failed to catch the second bolt that struck him in the chest, but as he staggered his fellows dragged him back. They shielded the [Knight] with their bodies as he staggered upright and opened his visor to down a potion. The Rose Knights locked formation, anchoring themselves against further death magic.

“That’s good! We won’t lose any more of them.”

Sacra was approving, but Reynold frowned.

“True, but we’ve just lost our advantage on the front.”

Sure enough, the concentration of Rose Knights on one side of the battlefield meant that the Goblins could now push forwards while they stalled the Rose Knights with expendable infantry and undead. A group of Hobs was rampaging towards the front, through the Soldiers who had lost the benefits of Zel’s Skill or were just too low-level to stop them.

The Hobs were cutting a line straight through the humans, trying to separate an entire group of them to be overrun. Magnolia saw eight Hobs, fighting in step. They turned as the Humans surged against them. Eight—no, was it seven? Magnolia blinked. Seven Hobs, wait, there were only *six* —

Another Hob fell as she watched. Magnolia gaped, seeing the Hob falling without spotting what had caused his death. Then she saw a shape moving around another Hob with a greataxe. The Hob turned, snarling, but Thomast was too quick. The [Duelist] ran his opponent through from behind, his enchanted rapier spearing the Hobgoblin in an instant. Quick as lightning, Thomast turned and his blade cut the air, wounding two Hobs from afar as they tried to encircle him.

“Thomast!”

Bethal’s voice made Magnolia’s ears ring. The [Lady] Walchaís was beside herself as her husband took down all eight Hobs and began rallying the Soldiers around him.

“We have the higher-level warriors it seems.”

“We do, but far fewer numbers. And the Goblin Lord is eager to reduce our count of elites.”

Sacra and Reynold were debating the battle amongst themselves. Magnolia turned her gaze across the battlefield, searching for the Goblin Lord once more. He was pushing to the front, but still entrenched well behind his army. *Not yet.* She spotted him at the same time Bethal did.

“What is he—no! *Thomast! He’s aiming towards you!*”

The Goblin Lord had spotted Thomast’s heroics on the front and his finger was aimed, black magic swirling around his hands and arm as he carefully targeted Thomast’s location.

“*Thomast!*”

Bethal would have run forwards into the battlefield herself to warn her husband. He was too far away to hear Bethal’s screams as Magnolia and Sacra had to hold her back with their combined strength. It was too late anyways. The Goblin Lord fired another [Deathbolt] as Thomast was fighting on the front.

The black slash of magic was streaking through the air, fast as an arrow, towards Thomast’s back. He was dueling a Hob, and he stepped forwards to pierce the Hob through his unarmored neck.

The Goblin Lord’s spell flashed towards Thomast’s back as he stepped forwards. The Chevalier pierced the Hob’s throat, and then *spun* out of the way, sidestepping the bolt of magic and letting it pierce the Hobgoblin instead. His foe fell, lifeless and bleeding from a hole in his throat. Thomast flicked his rapier, spraying the Goblin’s blood across another foe’s face and turned towards the Goblin Lord.

He bowed slightly and raised a hand and coolly beckoned to the Goblin Lord across the battlefield. Magnolia saw the black-eyed Goblin’s gaze widen slightly in incredulous anger. Lady Bethal stopped fighting Magnolia and Sacra and made a besmitten sound. Magnolia dropped her.

The Goblin Lord declined to answer Thomast's challenge and instead turned his magic towards other targets. Again he blasted a group of archers, taking out the unprotected Humans in small knots. They were helpless to defend themselves. However, the Goblin Lord's spells were only a single factor in a battle where thousands of arrows and spells were flying every minute. If that had been all, he would have done nothing. But then he pointed and Magnolia saw a group of eighteen bodies rise where they had fallen. The Humans turned in horror as eighteen Ghouls got up and began tearing into their unguarded ranks.

"Dead gods! He's starting to reanimate the undead behind our lines! Our archers and mages will be slaughtered!"

Reynold was aghast as he saw the undead begin to stir all across the back ranks of the Human army. Zombies and Ghouls were indeed rising as the Goblin Lord and his own [Necromancers] began to raise the dead. Sacra grabbed Reynold's arm as he started forwards.

"Calm down! General Shivertail planned for this!"

"How—"

Reynold was pointing at the carnage as the Ghouls began fighting the archers at close range. Then his eyes widened. He saw the flicker of black at the same time Magnolia did. She spotted a shape moving out of the shadows behind a Ghoul, stabbing it in the back, and another, slicing a Ghoul across the neck. Reynold gaped.

"Miss Ressa?"

The first Ghoul was an easy kill. It didn't notice Ressa as she stabbed it in the back. Her magical dagger, the Vision of Grasses, went into the undead's body with ease. It froze up as she pulled the dagger out.

The dagger that she had been given by Regis Reinhart wasn't meant for combat against the undead, but at least one of the myriad poisons it had been coated with still worked on an undead's nervous system. The Ghoul fell, paralyzed, and Ressa turned. She slashed across the face of another Ghoul as the archers around her shouted, surprised by both the undead and her appearance.

By her side, a man in black sliced across a Ghoul's throat. It was a good cut, but the undead was still alive. He had to hack at its neck as it fought to slash him. Only when he'd severed most of its head from its body did it fall.

"This is *not* how [Assassins] are meant to be used!"

Theofore the luckless [Assassin] screamed at Ressa as he turned his blades, slashing at one of the reanimated Ghouls. She grunted as she slid around another Ghoul and beheaded him with a slice of her dagger. Enchanted weapons were *very* nice to use. Theofore had to struggle as he repeatedly knifed another Ghoul in the chest.

"None of my Skills work on Ghouls! I can't poison or paralyze something that's *already* dead!"

"Shut up and stab."

The two turned as more undead began to rise. Ressa moved like a shadow, flicking from target to target as Theofore struggled to keep up. Across the battlefield more disguised [Maids] and [Butlers] appeared. Not all of Magnolia Reinhart's staff were good at domestic help. True, few of them were [Assassins], but they were high-level and enough to turn the tides.

For now. Ressa's eyes narrowed as she gazed around the battlefield. She was no [Strategist], but she had a sense of how the battle was going. They weren't losing, but she wasn't sure they were pulling that far ahead of the Goblins anymore. And then she heard the Goblin drums begin to beat and heard the shout.

"Commander charge!"

Commander charge. It was a term common to this world. It meant at least two [Commander] class leaders were leading a charge. And that mattered because such leaders were always high-level. When they charged a line, they could cut holes right through an enemy army.

And this time the Goblin Lord had sent *all* of his commanders. Former Goblin Chieftains, now his lieutenants, charged into the Human lines with their personal vanguards. And where they charged, Humans died.

Snapjaw, leading a group of Goblins on horses. Her teeth sank into a Human [Captain]'s throat, bearing him down as her Goblins charged through the broken Human unit. Eater of Spears, towering over the Hobs around him, breaking a group of seasoned [Lancers] as their weapons broke on his tough skin.

A Goblin with no face blasted ranks of Humans with fire as a [Beastmaster] Goblin rode a Shield Spider as large as the Goblin Lord's mount into battle, his spider snatching up Humans and tossing them screaming into the air. Across the battlefield the Goblin commanders were charging, and the Humans' lines began to buckle at last. Snapjaw grinned, raising her bloody head, turning to survey the landscape of despairing Human faces. Across from her, Noface was blasting Humans with fire

magic. On her other side, Illbreath was leading his Hobs forwards. This massive Hob had once swallowed an artifact that produced poison. Rather than die from ingesting it, he'd begun to breathe poisonous vapors. Now he advanced in a toxic cloud, the Humans ahead of him coughing and gagging, unable to put up a fight.

“Push! Push Humans!”

Snapjaw raised her sword, her teeth gnashing together. In front of her, the Humans were retreating! They were winning! She saw Goblins pushing forwards. Illbreath's unit was pursuing a group of fleeing Humans, cutting them down one by one—

And then Snapjaw got a bad feeling. A *bad* feeling. The kind she only had when death was imminent. Warned by her [Dangersense], the Hobgoblin turned and saw a blur heading her way. She screamed a warning to Illbreath.

“Tidebreaker!”

He turned. Zel Shivertail charged through the ranks of Goblins, trampling them, ignoring the blades that glanced off his armor and body. He collided with Illbreath in a clash of claws on steel. Snapjaw wheeled her mount, shouting, and saw other Goblin Chieftains running to the Hob's aid.

There was only thirty feet between her and Illbreath, no distance at all! Snapjaw saw the Hob breathing poison in Zel's face, raising his mace. The Drake [General] turned his head, coughing, was struck by the mace—

And then he grabbed Illbreath's head and tore it off his body. Snapjaw froze. Zel tossed the head to one side as Illbreath's corpse collapsed. He wiped at his eyes, sighed, and then blocked Snapjaw's sword with one hand.

Casually. Just like that. She screamed at him, lashing at the Drake with her sword, but his arms and claws were harder than steel! He punched her

mount and the horse screamed and fell. Snapjaw tumbled off the side, losing her grip on her sword. She saw the Drake [General] appear over her. His claw shot towards her face. She sat up and *bit*.

Her teeth had bitten through steel, through weak enchanted armor—even through a Wyvern’s hide! Snapjaw’s jaw engulfed Zel Shivertail’s hand with a *snap*, just like how she’d earned her name. She felt her teeth digging into his scales, piercing the General’s tough hide! Then she heard his voice.

“Ow.”

Zel Shivertail lifted his hand. Snapjaw rose, trying to bite into his tough skin. He punched her so hard her head rang, and then *threw* her. Snapjaw flew screaming through the air and hit a group of Goblins. She landed on their armor, shields, and a sword. The Hob rolled off the groaning Goblins and reached for the healing potion at her belt, gasping. She downed it and her vision cleared and the wound on her back closed. And then she looked towards Zel Shivertail and saw despair.

He was holding Noface’s head. The Drake [General] raised the faceless Goblin’s head, giving Snapjaw a clear view of the scar tissue that had replaced the Goblin’s entire face, the legacy of an encounter with a Human [Pyromancer]. He showed the Goblins their dead officer and then threw the head to the ground. The Goblins howled at him in rage. Zel waited.

And they did not advance. The Goblins held their ground, screaming, some daring to loose arrows at him or cast spells, but all too afraid to get in range of those deadly claws. Zel Shivertail towered over the Goblins, staring at them. Snapjaw froze in place, fear holding her heart. The Humans were one thing. But this?

The Tidebreaker turned away. He charged into another group of Goblins where the Human lines were faltering and Snapjaw heard her people

screaming. The Humans regained ground, shouting. Where the Tidebreaker went Goblins retreated.

He could not be stopped! Snapjaw found another horse, shoving a Goblin out of the saddle. She rode back towards the Goblin Lord, retreating. She had to let him know.

They could not kill Zel Shivertail. So they'd have to kill his army. That was the only way. Then they could surround him, beat him to death. But kill him with smaller numbers, with an army at his back?

Impossible. That knowledge was bitter on Snapjaw's tongue.

"They're pulling back! Look! I think General Shivertail's taken out another one of their commanders!"

The Humans standing and watching the battle cheered as Zel Shivertail downed another Hob. Where he went, the Human lines surged forwards and the Goblins retreated. He was truly inspiring, and Magnolia understood now how one [General] could defeat any number of [Strategists] or lesser officers. If you couldn't slay the [General], you couldn't stop him from tearing apart your army.

And yet, that was also a weakness. Sacra was the first to spot it.

"We're starting to buckle. Our lines are beginning to collapse."

"Surely not. We're *winning* on the front."

Magnolia pointed to the spot where Zel was fighting. Sacra nodded.

"Yes we are. And where the Rose Knights are fighting. But everywhere else—Sir Thomast is holding his side with General Shivertail's support, but

our left flank is being overrun by the undead!”

She indicated the left and Magnolia saw for the first time how far they’d been pushed by the undead. The overwhelming tide of bodies was thrusting the Humans back. The zombies didn’t care if their fellows were dying like flies—they’d push past their fallen friends and tear out a Human’s eyes while he was occupied with three more undead. And now some of the highest-level undead were advancing.

A Draug Drake was throwing [Soldiers] around, ignoring the arrows a battalion was sending into his body. He’d taken several cuts to his body, but nothing short of a solid axe blow would slow him. He was a juggernaut, and the other Crypt Lords, Draug, and higher undead were similarly hard to kill. Even the few Gold-rank adventurers were hard pressed to fight with them as undead crowded around from every angle.

“There’s just too many! The Goblins can push us on all sides and we can’t crush them in any one spot for fear of being overrun!”

“But we are winning, yes?”

Magnolia sharply looked at Sacra and the [Maid] nodded slowly, twirling her mace.

“If it’s a count of how many we’ve killed compared to how many they’ve killed, we are. But Lady Reinhart, numbers aren’t everything in a battle. A superior position could reverse all our gains in a moment.”

And as if her words were prophetic, Magnolia saw a disaster unfold right before her eyes.

The Human cavalry, some six thousand horse in total, had been a pivotal part of the battle despite their fewer numbers. The Human cavalry was a famous part of their fighting force, and they had employed their

superior mobility to great advantage, circling around the Goblins, striking from the rear and then moving away before they could be caught.

Now the Goblin Lord had focused on them. And Magnolia saw his [Deathbolts] begin to strike the cavalry at the same time two groups of Goblins on horseback and Goblins riding Shield Spiders set out to encircle them.

If they had been free from attack, the cavalry might have been able to make their escape. But a wall of seemingly preoccupied Goblin pikes shifted and revealed a battalion of hidden Goblin [Archers] that cut off one escape route with a deadly hail of arrows. Reynold groaned aloud as he saw the riders being cut down by the hundreds.

“Those idiots! *Evade!* Don’t they know how to dodge?”

“Incoming fire!”

Captain Salvia saw the Goblin Lord’s death magic strike the first group of [Riders] and turned her horse, trying to present as narrow a target as possible. She saw arrows and other magical spells blasting into the riders around her and screamed.

“Break formation! [Scatter Gallop]! Weave and dodge—don’t stay in one place!”

Her unit of [Riders] immediately broke out of their wedge formation and began to scatter, moving in unpredictable ways left and right as they fled. However, the rest of the cavalry had never trained in such techniques and fell prey to the arrows and spells hitting them from the side.

And then the Goblins charged into their flank. Salvia saw a Goblin with gleaming metal teeth and another Goblin riding an *enormous* Shield Spider leading the charge. They began tearing up the lines of her fellow riders, encircling them, threatening to tear their entire force apart!

That couldn't be allowed to happen. Salvia screamed an order and turned her horse.

“This way! Break up those Goblins! Keep moving! *Hurry!*”

She led her unit back towards the Goblins on horseback, trying to cut a path free. But the Goblins had the riders well and truly encircled now, and they were cutting the helpless riders down by the dozens with each passing second.

“Those fools! We're going to lose our horse! If they don't break out of that encirclement now—where are the [Commanders]? They should know how to escape!”

Reynold groaned aloud as he stared at the entrapped cavalry in the distance. Magnolia's hands were clenched. She glanced at the two covered wagons and then at the destructive tube artifact.

“Sakra, is there anything we can...?”

“Nothing we have will reach that far, Lady Reinhart. And General Shivertail most likely doesn't have the Skills to help them from that far away. I'm afraid they're lost.”

Sakra's face was pale as she stared at the slaughter. Reynold turned. Magnolia stared at him anxiously.

“Reynold, you were a [Lieutenant] once. Do you know what they could do?”

“They need to pick a weak spot and break out! There’s ways to slow down a pursuing force while escaping—I could do it myself if I—”

The [Butler]’s hands were clenched helplessly as he stared at the cavalry and then he broke off. His face changed and he turned to Magnolia with a curious, desperate light in his eyes.

“I may be able to save them. Lady Reinhart, may I have your permission to escort these good [Soldiers] to a safe spot? I fear I might place your transportation in jeopardy however.”

Magnolia’s eyes widened. She stared at her carriage.

“Escort them? Go, man! Run!”

He ran. And as he threw himself into the chair and flapped the reins, Magnolia saw the pink carriage shoot across the battlefield. Sacra stared at her mistress, worried.

“Lady Reinhart, is this wise? If we lose the carriage—”

“Sacra. Desperate times call for running people over. With an enchanted carriage.”

Magnolia interrupted her [Maid]. She watched Reynold streak across the battlefield as heads turned and the Goblins noticed him.

“Besides, I’m sure that Reynold will be perfectly civil to the Goblins. He does have a way with monsters. I think we’ve scraped off more [Bandits] from the sides of the carriage since he began driving than we ever did with all my other drivers. He does have a knack.”

Snapjaw was cutting down Humans on horseback, biting the necks of horses, when she heard a Goblin's voice.

“Fast-fast magic pink death thing coming this way!”

That was a loose translation and Snapjaw's head turned, in confusion. She realized at once what the Goblin meant. The pink carriage of nightmares hurtled towards her group of Goblins and Snapjaw screamed an order.

“Run!”

The Goblins turned too late. The pink carriage moved hundreds of miles per hour, faster than anything else on the battlefield. It *splattered* the first rank of Goblins and curved through their lines, headed straight for Eggsnatcher, the Goblin [Beastmaster] on top of his giant spider.

The collision between pink carriage and Eggsnatcher's mount was tremendous. Snapjaw saw several Goblins go flying, thrown by the impact, and then saw the Human [Butler] in the front of the carriage hacking at Eggsnatcher with a gleaming sword. The two traded blows as the carriage turned and sped away. Snapjaw breathed a sigh of relief for all of two seconds until she realized the horrible truth.

The carriage was coming *back*.

“This way! *Move your mounts, you flea-bitten slugs!*”

Salvia's head jerked around as she heard the roar of an officer's voice. But it was coming from the well-dressed [Butler] riding the pink carriage! In any other situation she might have had a few questions to ask, but here

the voice of authority was a light in the darkness. She turned her mount and rode desperately.

Behind her the cavalry streamed out of the gap Reynold's attacks had opened. The [Butler] drove his carriage around the horses, effortlessly weaving the massive vehicle through them, shouting.

“Break up! Stop galloping in a cluster or I’ll pull your damned helmets off and feed them to you! Move! I’ve seen wheelbarrows that rolled faster than you worthless sacks of shite!”

The profanity was nonsensical, abusive, exactly what the soldiers needed to hear. They moved, ignoring the Goblin death that was hot on their heels. Captain Salvia saw the [Butler] shift his grip on the reins and then spin the carriage. Quick as a flash he rammed into a group of Goblins that had nearly caught up to her unit and scattered horses and Goblins onto the ground. In pieces.

The impacts had to be taking a toll on the carriage, but the [Butler] kept it moving. He circled the Goblins, hitting the giant spider repeatedly but failing to knock it over. His attacks saved the cavalry, but the Goblins, frustrated by his attacks on them, began to circle the carriage instead.

Salvia was about to order her [Riders] to go back for the [Butler] when she heard him scream a phrase as he raced away from the Goblins towards an oncoming group of Goblin pikes.

“[Flying Wheels]!”

She turned her head and blinked as the pink carriage began to *fly*. It soared over the Goblin pikes as they gaped in amazement, up high over the battlefield. It was heading back away from the front lines. Salvia cheered as she saw the pink carriage make its escape, and then saw the Goblin Lord raise his hand.

He pointed, and a midnight bolt struck the [Butler] in the chest. He slumped in his chair and the carriage plummeted into the ground, scattering Humans and Goblins alike as it crashed across the front lines.

“*Reynold!*”

Sacra screamed as Magnolia’s heart stopped. She stared at the [Butler], slumped across the front of the pink carriage as Humans and Goblins alike surged around him.

He wasn’t moving. The Human [Soldiers] were valiantly trying to shield the [Butler] as the Goblins tried to climb onto the carriage. Magnolia’s hands dug into her palms. Was Reynold alive? The Goblin Lord’s spell had hit him squarely in the chest. But he was a high-level warrior and [Butler]! Maybe—

She could see Zel turning towards the [Butler], aware of Reynold’s plight. But the Goblin Lord was closer. And as Magnolia Reinhart watched, he began to move.

“The Goblin Lord is charging!”

A cry went up across the battlefield. The Goblin Lord and his vanguard began charging towards Reynold’s position on the field. Over a thousand Hobs and the Goblin Lord’s personal Shield Spider tore through a group of Humans, overrunning three Rose Knights and burying the Human lines in a sea of green. He was coming for Reynold. He wanted that carriage.

“It’s time.”

Magnolia took a breath. She pointed towards the Goblin Lord and her voice *snapped* across the battlefield.

“In the name of the Reinharts, I order you to slay that Goblin!”

To the side, the two covered wagons that had been so curiously abandoned in the mud *exploded*. Magnolia, Sacra, and Bethal ducked and a [Butler] held a parasol up as chunks of wood rained down around them. And standing in the remains of both wagons, two giants of metal unfolded. A glowing white eye turned to Lady Magnolia and a faceless Golem stood. His hands extended and his ‘fingers’ spread. Five razors splayed out and the War Golem, a full twelve feet of towering magical metal, stormed towards the lines of Goblins and Humans.

Screaming.

Magnolia Reinhart hadn’t been prepared for that. The War Golem emitted a terrifying *shrieking* sound as it ran—on all fours, like some demented dog—emitting a sound like a hundred shrieking children filled with pain and rage. It drew the Goblins’ attention. And as both Golems rammed into the Goblins’ ranks from the side, they began to fight.

War Golems. Behemoths made from another era. These weren’t Archmage Zelkyr’s personal creations, but they had been made during the same era his Golems had dominated the world stage. They had been made to slaughter enemy armies by the thousands. And that’s what they did.

The first Golem swung a hand full of razors as it crashed into a group of Goblins. It beheaded a group of them and then the glowing white light in its ‘mouth’, the only actual feature on its face, turned red. It spat a beam of blazing red light across a rank of Goblins, incinerating everything it touched in an instant. By its side, the other Golem’s body glowed and it began to arc bolts of lightning, which struck nearby Goblins and Humans alike and earthed themselves on their armor.

Goblins fell as the two Golems raced through their lines, straight towards the Goblin Lord. He turned, and Magnolia was glad to see his eyes

widen in fear or horror for the first time. He raised a hand and a black [Deathbolt] struck one of the Golems squarely in the chest—

And did nothing. The Golems were neither alive nor dead. They raced towards the Goblin Lord, overrunning even Hobs with their sheer size. He was turning his mount, retreating, but too late. The first Golem was about to leap on him when a gigantic Hob tackled it.

Eater of Spears, one of the Goblin Lord's lieutenants, knocked the first War Golem off-balance. The huge Hob snarled. He was actually shorter than the War Golem by a few feet! But he began trading blows with the metal behemoth, ignoring the crimson beam that set his body afire. He roared as he fought and the second Golem found itself surrounded by Hobs who beat at the metal monster as it fought to get at the Goblin Lord.

“He’s going to get away!”

Magnolia’s hands clenched. The Goblin Lord was retreating, scattering the Humans who were pursuing him with his black magic as his warriors screened him from the two War Golems. Soon he was well behind enemy lines and Magnolia had to call the War Golems back or risk them becoming overwhelmed in the sea of Goblins. The Goblins weren’t idiots—they were trying to pull the Golems down with ropes and crack their metal bodies with mauls and sledgehammers.

“It looks like General Shivertail’s reached Reynold!”

Sacra cried out as Zel Shivertail reached Reynold’s coach. With the War Golems screening him, the Drake shook Reynold. Magnolia and the others cried out in relief as the [Butler] woke up, looking disoriented. He weakly drank the potion that Zel offered him and then sped away from the battlefield. To Magnolia’s surprise, Zel Shivertail rode with him.

“General! Are you alright?”

Magnolia strode towards Zel, concerned, as Sacra and Bethal helped Reynold down. The [Butler] was very pale, but he was alive, and so Magnolia focused all her attention on Zel.

“I’m fine, Magnolia.”

Zel panted as he wiped sweat and blood from his face. He uncorked a second potion and downed half the bottle, grimacing.

“I’m exhausted. Been fighting—if this goes longer we’ll have to rotate groups, feed the soldiers—but it shouldn’t.”

“How is the battle going?”

Magnolia watched the Drake’s face carefully. Zel turned back towards the battlefield and grimaced. He pointed with one claw.

“It’s still too even for my liking! That damned Goblin Lord—he’s forced us to withdraw those pink [Knights] and he keeps aiming for our high-level warriors! We’re getting pushed too far by the undead—there’s too many of them! [Surge of Strength]! [Scything Arms]!”

He pointed to a group of struggling Soldiers and they began to push forwards, their blades suddenly hacking apart zombies with ease. Zel sighed.

“I’m using my Skills, but it’s a draw so far. I can keep cutting down Goblins all day, but the Goblin Lord’s doing the same and they have more Goblins...those two War Golems are tearing up their flanks, though.”

“I’m ashamed to say I might have used them too early. If I had waited—I was concerned for my [Butler], General Shivertail. I do apologize.”

The Drake shook his head, pouring water over his face and chest as a [Maid] handed him a canteen.

“It was the right call. That carriage was too powerful to fall into their hands. I’d question using it, but your butler saved all our remaining horse—good man. Drop the honorifics, Magnolia. Call me Zel when we’re in the field.”

She smiled, surprised by the sudden change in attitude. Zel looked around, dripping, and his eyes narrowed as he found the Goblin Lord’s form, again entrenched behind his soldiers.

“I don’t like this.”

“We are winning, aren’t we?”

The Drake shrugged.

“We’re cutting down more of them than they are of us...but that doesn’t matter since they outnumber us two to one, does it? I don’t want this to become a battle of attrition, but the Goblin Lord’s realized I’m hunting down his lieutenants. If I can’t get to him or the other important Goblins, this could get ugly.”

He sighed, his eyes focusing on the War Golems as they held a section of the line, tearing up the Goblins around them.

“We should have unleashed the Golems earlier. That was my fault. I didn’t think the Goblin Lord would hesitate to charge in for so long. But if they had gotten him—”

“How do you wish to proceed? *Is* there a way to corner the Goblin Lord? Or must we simply eradicate his army first?”

“I’m thinking. That trick with the carriage—can you make it fly again?”

Zel addressed Reynold, who had come over. The [Butler] saluted, pale-faced.

“I can, General. But I’m wary of flying it once more—that Goblin Lord is an expert shot. I was attempting to dodge but—”

“I understand. Magnolia, if I propose a dangerous strategy would you lend me Reynold? I can’t guarantee either he or I will survive, but it might end the battle now.”

Magnolia hesitated. She looked at Zel and at Reynold.

“Do you think it will work? Is it worth the risk? What am I saying; it must be if you’re asking. Go! We will support you as best we can!”

“Thank you. Reynold, I need you to drop me off by Thomast’s position first.”

“Yes sir!”

The carriage spun back across the battlefield. Magnolia watched them go and turned to Sacra.

“Do you agree with General Zel’s assessment?”

Sacra ducked her head.

“I do, milady. This battle’s had its turns, but neither side is crushing the other. If there’s a way to end it faster, I’d agree with General Shivertail that it’s worth attempting. The longer this goes on the more exhausted our forces become, and the Goblin Lord can start rotating fresh troops in or use his undead. We can’t.”

“I see. Then we must trust—”

Magnolia broke off. There was a group of Goblins approaching her small escort, and she could see more Goblin archers turning towards them.

“Oh dear. It looks like the Goblin Lord has finally noticed us.”

Indeed, Reynolds' contribution to the battle, not to mention the appearance of the War Golems and Zel Shivertail's impromptu conference, had drawn the ire of the Goblin Lord. His archers sent a shower of arrows flying through the air towards Magnolia's position. She sighed.

"Bethal? It's time."

Both [Ladies] straightened, and as the arrows flew downwards, Magnolia lightly gritted her teeth and whispered a Skill.

"[Deft Hand]."

She reached up and *pushed* the arrows out of the sky with a flick of her wrist as Bethal used her [Tranquil Skies] Skill to the same effect. It was a thousand times harder than nudging someone across the ballroom or accidentally pushing a [Waiter] so he spilled a drink at the right moment, but Magnolia was a high-level [Lady]. She saw the flight of arrows hit the ground a good twenty paces to her right and sighed in relief.

"Now for the cavalry. Oh, I see we have some of our own coming to our rescue."

Indeed, a group of riders led by Captain Salvia was racing towards them, but the Goblins would arrive first. Magnolia sighed again, and this time as the Goblins were about to trample over them she raised one hand and flicked it.

"[Polite Deflection]. Shoo."

The Goblins *swerved* before colliding with the [Lady] and her escort, much like an unfortunate suitor deflected on the dance floor. Magnolia saw their charge slow, and then her [Maids] and [Butlers] charged into their number with Sacra at their head at the same time the Human [Riders] hit them from behind. The Goblins were routed in a matter of moments and Magnolia enjoyed seeing the Goblin Lord's baleful stare.

She was a bit disappointed he didn't try casting magic at her—she'd never reflected a spell with [Deft Hands] before, but she was sure she could send it right back at him with a bit of practice.

“Milady, are you unharmed?”

Sacra returned with blood on her mace and Magnolia gently pushed Sacra back with the tip of her finger before the woman could get blood on her dress. It wasn't for vanity's sake either.

“I'm fine, Sacra. I know you'd rather have me run around in armor and a shield, but my Skills as a [Lady] only work if I am sufficiently *ladylike*. And while Bethal may run about in the nude and keep her Skills, I am, alas, a bit more genteel than that.”

“You used to run about naked with me, Magnolia. Don't act so prim and proper.”

Bethal scowled at Magnolia and both ladies watched the servants push away the corpses of the Goblins with some satisfaction. A [Lady] might be a rose, but a rose had thorns. The Goblins had learned that during the last Antinium War as well.

“Well, enough of this. I want to see what Zel Shivertail has in mind.”

Magnolia swept her eyes across the battlefield, forgetting about the dead Goblins around her. She spotted Zel as he cut a path towards Thomast. Her eyes narrowed as the two conferred and then Zel headed back towards the carriage.

This was it. Magnolia knew that the Drake was planning something that would end up with the Goblin Lord's head. It could be a simple ploy, or a complex one, but her intuition told her that simple might work far better than complex. Either way, the battle hinged on Zel Shivertail's plan.

They *were* winning. She kept telling herself that. For all his strength, the Goblin Lord had declined to meet Zel Shivertail in battle and none of his best warriors had slowed the Drake [General]. So long as Zel Shivertail remained standing there was hope. No, more than hope, they could win!

So why was she so vaguely uneasy? Magnolia Reinhart didn't know. She stared at the battlefield as it reached its most critical moment and she edged just slightly to the left. Towards the pedestal with the magical artifact her grandfather had given her on it. A magical tube. It made things explode, or so he'd said. Very dangerous. You could kill a Great Chieftain of the Goblins with it. Or—if need be—

A Goblin Lord. Magnolia waited. It wasn't as though she had to use it. It was just in case things went south. She just hoped her aim was good. Well, even if it wasn't it would probably be spectacular.

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Outside of Invrisil, a battle was being fought between an army of Goblins and an army of Humans. The cold, muddy ground was warmed with blood and fresh bodies. Both sides struggled against each other, shouting, and the clash of arms filled the air. The battle had been long. The battle had been short.

To Osthia Blackwing, held captive in the heart of the Goblin army, it felt as though the battle had gone on for a week, and yet, at the same time, it had felt like it had rushed by in the course of minutes. She estimated that the true length was just over two hours. She had been forced to watch it all, as Goblins crashed into the ranks of Humans with their undead allies.

Crashed and broke. Despite their superior numbers, the thousands of elite Hobs, and the presence of the undead, the Goblins had failed to overwhelm the Human army time and time again. And indeed, they had been forced back, humbled by one figure who had made the battlefield swirl around him.

Zel Shivertail.

Now Osthia watched him streak back across the battlefield, carried by a pink magical carriage that scythed across the Goblin front-line, running down any Goblin careless enough to get in its way. She was not the only one with her attention on the Drake [General]. The Goblin Lord sat astride his massive Shield Spider mount, staring at Zel Shivertail with narrowed eyes. He spoke, his voice filled with hatred and frustration.

“Why is he so strong?”

Silence greeted his question. The Goblin Lord's lieutenants stood around him. Eater of Spears, Snapjaw, the Goblin [Beastmaster]...none could say it aloud. Their numbers had been cut down by Zel already. Now the Goblin Lord's eyes turned to Osthia. She glared at him, her mouth gagged.

"What is he doing?"

Coming for you. She glared, her jaw working against the tight leather strips holding her mouth shut. The Goblin Lord nodded. He stared at Zel, and then turned to his lieutenants.

"Prepare. He is coming."

The Goblins shuddered. He was coming. The hero of the Antinium Wars, the famous [General of the Line], the Tidebreaker. Those titles had been just words before. Now they were all too real. The Goblin Lord's army was superior to the Human one, but the Goblin Lord had yet to meet Zel Shivertail on the field of battle. Now that was going to change.

Osthia could feel it. Zel Shivertail was not the kind of [General] who would risk a prolonged battle against the Goblin Lord, whose army was matched against his. He was coming.

She hoped he knew he was walking into a trap.

Faces. That was what you saw on a battlefield. Faces. Even if you didn't want to—at close range, that was all you could see. You saw the enemy as you gutted them with your claws or with a sword. Their faces, sometimes covered beneath helmets, sometimes full of hate or despair. It was easy to

see only the enemy in them, but it was strange how there was a person behind each [Soldier]’s face. The Goblins looked like people sometimes.

Zel Shivertail gripped the side of Magnolia Reinhart’s carriage, feeling the wind blasting off his scales. He saw the battlefield flash by him. Hundreds, thousands of faces turned his way. Human [Soldiers], cheering as they saw the Drake [General] flash by, Goblins, drawing back in fear and hatred. Zel glanced ahead and saw Reynold driving the coach with minute flicks of the reins. The [Butler]’s face was pallid and his hands shook a bit, but he was still upright, still driving with impeccable accuracy.

“Good man.”

Zel waited until he saw his target in the crowd. Another man who stood out in the sea of armored bodies. The [Chevalier] Thomast fought in a doublet of red and gold cloth, much of which had been stained a deeper crimson still by blood. Not his. The clothing was probably enchanted, but Thomast had yet to take a blow. The [Duelist] and [Chevalier] fought with rapid thrusts and lunges that took down his opponents before they could strike. He turned as Zel leapt, scattering enemies and allies with his landing.

“Get ready to execute the plan! Turn and pick me up!”

Zel roared at Reynold and saw the coach speed off and turn—into the Goblin lines. Again the green-skinned monsters scattered, screaming and crying out in pain and horror as the carriage crushed them mercilessly.

Monsters. People. Zel turned his head and looked at Thomast. The [Duelist] was breathing heavily, but like Zel, he was ready to fight. They were the highest-level warriors on the field, or so Zel sensed. Funny, he didn’t know if he’d ever said more than a few words to the man.

“I’m turning over control of the left flank to you! Hold your ground or we’ll be overrun!”

“Leave it to me.”

Thomast nodded as Zel pointed, shouting over the roar of Humans and Goblins clashing. There were a thousand things that he could have said. The [Duelist] could have pointed out his lack of experience or Skills in battlefield command, the dangers of turning over strategy to someone else, or simply asked what Zel was doing. He did none of those things and instead turned his attention back to the battle. Zel was grateful. He ran forwards, cut down a charging Hob with a slash of his claws, leapt—and caught hold of the carriage as it streaked by the other way.

Three Goblins had grabbed on as well and had been crawling towards Reynold with daggers in hand. They took one look at Zel and let go. Zel saw their bodies disappear into the mass of Goblins as the coach turned. He gritted his teeth as he pulled himself closer to the front. All the pieces were in a row.

“Let’s do this. You ready?”

Reynold nodded. The [Butler] flicked the reins and the two spoke at once. Reynold uttered a command as the carriage sped towards the edge of the battle.

“[Flying Wheels]!”

Zel felt the coach lift *up*, and felt his stomach drop. He ignored the sensation and raised one claw.

“[Rapid Maneuvering]! [Hold the Line]! [Vanguard of Steel]!”

He felt the Skills take hold on the Human army below him immediately. Zel looked down as Humans changed formations, obeying orders he had given. Below him, the battlefield began to shift.

“What’s he doing?”

From her vantage point apart from the battle, Magnolia Reinhart saw the established lines of battle break and Human [Soldiers] adopt a strange formation. They pushed past the undead and Goblins, encircling them from the right with cavalry and infantry alike crashing into the Goblin formations. A thin wave of Human [Soldiers] trapped the Goblins from the right, but so few that they were a single line compared to the green mass that began pushing back against them.

“That cannot be sound strategy. Sacra? What is General Shivertail thinking?”

“He used a Skill. [Vanguard of Steel]—can’t you feel it?”

Sacra turned her head, breathing heavily. Magnolia frowned and pinched herself.

“No, I can’t.”

“I can. General Shivertail’s Skill is—look!”

Sacra pointed. Magnolia saw the thin wave of Humans that should have been immediately overwhelmed by the Goblin numbers holding their ground, roaring as they traded blows with the Goblins. She saw a young woman in armor take a sword strike to her unguarded neck. But rather than drop, the sword bounced *off* her skin.

Steel bodies. Magnolia’s eyes widened.

“I say, how long will the effects last?”

“Not too long. But they don’t need to.”

Indeed, the Goblins were in disarray as their opponents suddenly became immortal foes, almost impervious to harm. They drew back, and

Magnolia saw another strange event take place. Pink, armored [Knights] began striding across the battle lines, hacking their way through Goblins, spacing themselves out across the center and left flank where the undead were pushing at the Human [Soldiers].

“He’s broken up my Knights of the Petal again. What is he doing? The Goblin Lord will begin attacking them again.”

Bethal stared as her Rose Knights began pushing the Goblin lines back. Magnolia glanced up, towards a flying carriage moving across the battlefield.

“I believe the Goblin Lord is about to have his hands full, Bethal.”

Every head looked up. They saw the pink carriage flying over the Goblin Lord’s army. A black bolt rose to meet it. Magnolia’s hands clenched as she saw Reynold frantically swerve to avoid it. But then they saw the carriage dip, and dive. A second lance of death magic shot forwards—a clawed hand blocked it. Zel Shivertail clung to the side of the carriage. He was right over the Goblin Lord’s head now. Magnolia saw his arm tense—then he let go and *dropped*.

A hundred feet. Fifty feet. Twenty. The ground—

Zel landed with an impact that knocked the wind out of him. The *thud* was more like an explosion. He could feel dirt fountaining up around him, feel the crushing pain of impact. For a second the Drake lay there, stunned. Then he moved.

Up Zel rose. A claw shot out and slashed a Hob who’d tried to swing at him, thinking Zel would be too slow to react. Zel felt his claws shear

through the Hob's armor and flesh like parchment. He withdrew his hand and the Hob fell.

Goblins. Zel stood and looked around. There were thousands of them, all staring at him. Many had open mouths. Some were still staring at Reynold as the [Butler] carried his carriage out of danger. They were stunned, unable to believe Zel had survived the fall.

Strength. Zel's body hurt a tiny bit from the fall. But he had fallen further and survived. He'd fallen off a cliff once. And the danger of dropping into the middle of an army of Goblins? Zel had fought against Drakes, Humans, Antinium—all without more than basic steel armor and his claws. What was this compared to fighting a Drake Lord of the Wall?

And yet, they stared as if he were the monster. Zel wanted to laugh at them. They were afraid of him for surviving a fall from the sky? This was normal. This was what high-level battles were like. The first breath of air in Zel's lungs was sweet. He inhaled, and then roared.

“Goblin Lord!”

His voice caused a hush across the battlefield. Zel turned, staring around for the Goblin Lord's figure, or that of his spider. He saw neither. The Goblins were moving to surround him. Where was the Goblin Lord? Zel twisted around again as he heard a voice.

“General Shivertail!”

Someone was shouting his name. And the voice—Zel saw a bound shape. A Drake with bright yellow scales was fighting on the ground, her arms and legs bound.

A Drake? Zel stared, shocked. She was an Oldblood Drake. A captive? She'd managed to loosen a leather muzzle on her mouth. Now she screamed at him.

“It’s a trap! Get away, sir! The Goblin Lord—”

She turned and sprayed acid from her mouth at a Hob. He screamed in agony and another clubbed her down from behind with a mace. Zel looked around. All he saw were Hobs. And they had enchanted weapons, wands, bows—

The first arrow Zel blocked on an arm. The other eight glanced off his scales. The bolt of lightning made his side tingle and ache, but his armor caught most of the magic. The Drake turned and caught a sledgehammer blow to the side. He grabbed the Hob who’d hit him and pressed his claws into the Hob’s eyes. Digging deep. She screamed and died.

Turn. A sword slashed across Zel’s face. He felt the tip cutting through his outer scales, drawing a line of blood. An enchanted blade. Zel twisted before it could keep cutting and lashed out. Another killing blow. The Goblins stared as two Hobs fell. Zel wiped the blood from his scales and looked around.

Goblins all around. They closed in, their faces afraid, staring. Zel laughed and spread his arms wide.

“For Izril! Sserys and the Drakes!”

They were afraid to come to him, so he went to them. Zel charged alone, into the ranks of the Goblins. He cut them down, trying to find a single figure in the midst of the army.

Where was the Goblin Lord?

“Incredible.”

Sacra breathed the word, her eyes wide. Magnolia saw the blaze of golden-red armor, the sole Drake in the center of the Goblins' army. Zel Shivertail was a whirlwind, cutting Hobs down as they rushed him from every angle.

It was a sight to motivate the Human army, which was pushing back the Goblins, riding on the momentum of their [Vanguard of Steel] effect. And yet, Magnolia felt nothing but anxiety as she stared into the heart of the battle.

"Where is the Goblin Lord? General Shivertail is alone."

No one answered. Bethal, Sacra, and the other servants were transfixed, staring at Zel. Magnolia looked around and then kicked Bethal in the rear. The other woman stumbled.

"Magnolia—!"

"Stop gaping and *look*, Bethal! If the Goblin Lord escapes then General Shivertail will be well and truly cut off. I don't think Reynold can get back to him!"

It was true. The pink carriage was under attack as Goblins loosed arrows and spells at it. Magnolia knew that the carriage wasn't *that* invulnerable—the enchantments might well be breaking. Reynold was already trying to steer it away from the battlefield. She kicked Sacra and gave the same order.

"*Find the Goblin Lord!* We are the only ones who can look!"

The other servants and Bethal turned their gaze to the battlefield. Magnolia stared through the sea of Goblins, trying to connect the Goblin Lord's visage to the milling crowd of Goblins. It was damnably hard—and not least because the Goblins *did* look alike at this distance! And yet, he had to be out there. If only she could find out where before he escaped

completely. Zel Shivertail had been nearly on top of him and the Goblin Lord couldn't have moved that far—

A swirl in the army caught her attention. Magnolia saw the Goblins moving slightly, eddying around something. The [Lady]'s eyes narrowed. She was no battlefield expert, but she'd seen more than one ballroom where one person was at the center of attention. She *was* the center of attention most of the time.

“There!”

Bethal had seen the same thing. She pointed a finger and Magnolia saw the Goblin Lord. He was dismounted, leading his Shield Spider away through a screen of Hobs. He hadn't gone more than fifty feet in the chaos and he was moving slowly, confident that Zel couldn't spot him through the waves of Goblins surrounding him.

What arrogance. For a second Magnolia could almost admire his casual retreat. Then she smiled and a glint appeared in her eyes.

“A shame you and I will never meet in the realm of politics. You might have done better there than on the battlefield.”

Sacra glanced at Magnolia, only having heard the last of what her mistress had said. She stared at the Goblin Lord, her hands clenched on her mace.

“There he is. But how can we get General Shivertail's attention?”

“Oh, that's quite simple.”

Magnolia's fingers raised and she carefully flicked her hand at Zel Shivertail as he cut down another Hob with his claws. She pitched her voice so and tilted her hand as if she was cupping his chin in her hand. She turned her hand and whispered.

“Look over there.”

Across the battlefield Zel Shivertail’s head turned. Magnolia saw his body jerk and his eyes widened. He stared for a second and then charged *into* a Hob who was running at him. The Drake lifted one hand as he used the Hob as a shield. One hand, raised in thanks. Then he was charging. And she heard his voice.

“Turn and face me, coward!”

And the Goblin Lord turned. There was only a hundred feet separating the two as Zel Shivertail and the Goblin Lord locked eyes. The Goblin motioned and a wall of Goblins surged forwards. Zel Shivertail roared and charged.

“Golems!”

Magnolia’s voice was distant but the two War Golems heard. They raised their heads and abandoned their posts, charging into the Goblin army and heading for the Goblin Lord. She heard Bethal shouting at her Rose Knights and saw them slicing into the army. Suddenly, the Goblins were trying to hold back pink [Knights] and a pair of armored giants and Zel Shivertail himself. All headed straight for the Goblin Lord.

To his credit, he held his ground. The Goblin Lord refused to run. He mounted his Shield Spider and began firing black bolts of magic at Zel Shivertail. The Drake absorbed the magic, letting it splash over his enchanted armor, dodging others. Charging.

Unstoppable! The Goblins tried to block him with spears, grabbing at the General, throwing their bodies in front of him. But nothing worked. Zel came on, roaring, and Magnolia saw a pair of Goblins moving forwards to stop him.

He was coming. Snapjaw's mouth was dry with fear as she heard Zel Shivertail roaring. He was cutting a path through her people like they were made of grass! And he was heading to the Goblin Lord, her hope, the hope of her people.

He had to be stopped. She ran forwards with Eater of Spears. The two Hobs were ready to die to stop the Drake. Snapjaw raised her enchanted sword.

“Go left!”

She screamed at Eater of Spears. He roared and charged towards the Drake's left. Snapjaw ran right. She could stab him from behind. She'd poisoned this blade. All she needed was one good strike and—

Snapjaw's legs carried her past Zel Shivertail as he spun to face both her and Eater of Spears. Snapjaw blinked, tried to turn, and failed. She ran past the Drake [General], unable to turn. It was as if someone was holding her in place! And then she heard a voice.

A Human woman's voice. It whispered in her ears.

“This way, my dear.”

Snapjaw fought against the voice, tried to slow her legs. But the voice was powerful and it held her. For three seconds. That was all. But by that time it was too late. Snapjaw turned, weeping, and saw the end.

There he was. The Goblin Lord was sitting across his giant Shield Spider, only a few paces in front of Zel. The Drake [General] clenched his

fists.

A huge Hob blocked his way. Zel looked up as Eater of Spears blocked his path. The Hob was a giant. His face was set, his eyes locked on Zel's face. The two paused for a second as Goblins drew back, seeing one of their heroes facing the Drake [General].

Zel spoke.

"You can't stop me."

Eater of Spears paused. He stared at Zel, his face solid, grim, unflinching. He spoke, a bass rumble.

"Can try."

He charged forwards, fist swinging fast. Zel leapt forwards as well and the two met in a clash of fist and claw. The Drake [General] slipped around the Hobgoblin's fist and slashed *left-right* across Eater of Spears' chest. He tore the Hob's front open but the Goblin refused to fall. Bleeding, his body staining crimson, he lashed out and hit Zel in the chest with a mighty punch.

The Drake grunted and spun with the impact. He slashed again—this time Eater of Spears made a sound like a groan and Zel's claws bounced off bone. His ribs. Flesh sundered, the Hob was too slow. Zel sprinted past him and Eater of Spears fell backwards, grasping weakly for the last healing potion at his belt. Only, Zel had crushed it sometime during the exchange of blows.

Unstoppable.

There was one last wall of Hobs between him and the Goblin Lord. Zel counted. Six—four—three—two—

The last two Hobs fell back, fighting furiously, until they heard a voice. They moved backwards, and Zel saw the Goblin Lord staring down at him.

The Goblin was tall as a normal Human man, and proportioned in much the same way. He was no giant, no inhumanly large monster. But then, Velan hadn't been either.

This Goblin was no Goblin King. But he still faced Zel, unafraid. His hands grasped a black blade of magic. He pointed it at Zel and the [General] opened his crimson claws. They stared at each other for a second.

And then Zel charged. He roared as he came, and in the distance the Human army screamed and shouted. The Goblin Lord charged, and the Goblins around him howled defiance.

The Shield Spider lashed out at Zel, trying to trap him with its legs, biting. The Goblin Lord swung—Zel ducked under both black blade and legs and found the Shield Spider's belly. He cut into its center and tore pieces of carapace from its body.

The Shield Spider screamed. It bled as Zel dodged back, a pale blue ichor. The Goblin Lord raised his finger and shot a blast of death magic at Zel. The [Deathbolt] pierced Zel at point-blank range. He stumbled. But did not fall.

“Not enough. [Titan's Cut]!”

Zel raised his claws and slashed. The arc of his claws traced through the air, and the air itself *bent* as he cut. An imprint of four claw marks opened up across the Shield Spider's entire body and it screamed. The massive strike severed one of its legs, crushed another at the base, and opened up its bulbous abdomen. The giant spider collapsed in a bloody pool and the Goblin Lord tumbled from its back. Zel walked forwards, claws ready.

The Goblin Lord had fallen behind his spider's abdomen, out of view. Zel walked around the side, trying to get a good look. He saw a foot—then the Goblin Lord. The Goblin rose, pointing at Zel's chest—

“[Bone F—]”

“*[Antimagic Slash]!*”

Zel’s claws went through a barrier of magic and into the Goblin Lord’s side. He *tore*—the Goblin Lord screamed as Zel ripped his stomach open.

Blood, red and wet, splashed to the ground. The Goblin Lord stared down at his open stomach and then up at Zel.

“Oh.”

That was all he said. It was such a normal word. Zel nodded. He stepped forwards, his claws open.

Goblins screamed as they saw their leader fall. They swarmed Zel. He turned and cut them down. Regular soldiers, fighting a [General]. He was five steps away from the Goblin Lord.

Four.

Three.

Two.

One—

“*Do it!*”

Gershal of Vaunt screamed the words as he carried Salvia away from her downed mount. His voice joined thousands of others. The Humans roared, cheering.

“Finish him.”

Magnolia clenched her hands as she saw Zel cutting down Goblins left and right. They were all over him, leaping on the General's back, trying to hold him back—trying to save their Lord. But Zel stepped forwards. He was close. So close. She saw his claws raise—

And then a pillar of white blocked her view. Magnolia blinked. She saw something—a yellowish-white thing—erupt from the ground. A pillar? No, more like a spike of ivory. A wall of bone. Magnolia inhaled.

And then she saw another. A spire of bone shot out of the ground, impaling a Hob and two smaller Goblins. More bone pillars began rising out of the ground in a circle around Zel and the Goblin Lord. They grew like obscene flowers, stained red with the Goblins they impaled, raising higher, higher—

“Magnolia. What’s happening?”

Bethal stared at the bone walls as they knitted together, forming a dome in the middle of the battlefield. A circular wall of ivory engulfed Zel and the Goblin Lord, blocking them from view from every direction. Bethal looked from Magnolia to Sacra, her face pale.

“Is it a spell or—”

“I don’t know.”

Magnolia whispered. Her heart was suddenly beating very fast. She stared at the dome of bone. It couldn’t be the work of the Goblin Lord. If he could cast that spell he would have done so before Zel reached him. But if not him, then there could be only one other person who cast the spell.

Az’kerash.

And now Magnolia truly felt afraid. She stared at the ivory wall as Goblins began to bang on the impenetrable bone with their weapons. She turned to Sacra.

“Get me all the [Mages] you can find! Open that dome now!”

Zel twisted as he saw the bone spires rising from the ground. He saw the Goblin Lord’s eyes widen, and felt that sense of unease at the back of his mind spike into bells of alarm. He turned, ignoring the Goblin Lord, and saw the walls of bone close, obscuring the sky overhead. Suddenly, everything was dark.

Only his enchanted breastplate shed any kind of light in the enclosed space. Zel eyed the smooth ivory walls, wondering if he could break them. Then he felt...something.

Magic. It was a palpable presence at times, when great spells were cast. Zel could feel it being concentrated here, a tingling on his scales. He looked around and saw the air *shimmer*.

It wasn’t a tear in space, or a portal. It was more like a bridge or an—opening—that someone stepped through. The air twisted, and a shape stepped out of the shadows. Zel saw a bone-white woman, no, a woman *made* of bone, a giant wearing bone armor and holding a sword and shield step out. She stared at him with green eyes that blazed with undead light.

And she spoke. One word.

“Venitra.”

The air moved. Zel turned and saw more shadows flickering, becoming people. Four more figures stepped into place. A skeleton of black bone, dressed in a [Mage]’s robes. The flames in her eyes glowed gold as she twirled the staff in her hand.

“Ijvani.”

A woman, a rotting corpse, walked out to Zel's left. By her side, a strange figure dressed in a trench coat, a humanoid creature with no face, features concealed by a hat. The rotting undead spoke for both of them.

“Bea. And Oom.”

And the last, a Gnoll dressed in armor. His eyes glowed blue. His body was dead, but for the light in his eyes he might have been alive. He was powerful, taller than Zel, and he had a sword that glowed with magic in one hand. He spoke last, his voice deep, booming in the enclosed space.

“Kerash.”

The five undead stood in the dome. Zel's heart was pounding in his chest. He stared from face to face. They had entered this place with a spell. Not [Invisibility]. He would have sensed it. No, the spell, the way they seemed to appear—[Teleport]? [Greater Teleport]? They had to have used an artifact.

There was no time to ask what was happening. No reason to either, really. Zel looked from face to face, and focused on Kerash. The undead Gnoll raised his sword and pointed at Zel's chest.

“Surround the Drake.”

The five undead moved around the dome, trying to flank him. Zel backed up until his back was at one of the bone walls. Bea and Oom took his left side, while Venitra and Ijvani his right. Kerash stood in front of him. The five undead readied themselves, waiting. Zel eyed them as he shifted, his stance low, his claws open.

Five. Each undead was clearly unique. They all radiated danger, but—he appraised them quickly.

Venitra, the undead bone woman, was clearly some kind of [Knight]. She looked like a kind of golem. Dangerous, but not unbeatable. The

skeleton by her side—the way she held her staff reminded Zel of something. Had he met her before? She was a spellcaster, but that too was manageable.

The real threat was coming from Zel's left. He had no idea what the rotten 'Bea' could do, but all his instincts screamed at him *not* to let her touch him. As for Oom—Zel risked a glance and saw a featureless, smooth face. Oom's body was black, almost translucent, and the way he stood—the trench coat and hat were concealing something. He had no face. Was he even humanoid?

Kerash was the last. Zel thought he was a Draugr of some kind. They were powerful, hard to kill and strong, but it was only the enchanted sword that could hurt him. Get rid of that and—

Too many. Zel knew he was tired, but even if he had been rested, five high-level enemies at once would be—his eyes narrowed. He glanced towards the Goblin Lord, but the Goblin was trying to hold his guts in. Good. Even a healing potion wouldn't heal that quickly. He had been shocked to see the bone walls go up. So he hadn't planned this.

"So you've sent your minions to do what you're too afraid to do in person, Az'kerash?"

The undead shifted when Zel spoke their master's name. As if they were surprised. But who else could it be? Zel looked from face to face. Yes, who else?

"It seems you've planned this well. Did you plan on stabbing me in the back or were you always hoping that I might walk into a trap like this? Come out and face me yourself, coward. I know you're watching."

His words made the fires in the eyes of the undead glow brighter. Zel watched the bone woman—Venitra's—eyes blaze bright green. So they could feel emotion. That was important to know.

A cold, precise voice filled the air in the dome, echoing. Zel had only heard Az'kerash speak a few times, but he could never forget that voice.

"I had intended to slay you at Liscor, but circumstances forced me to abandon that plan. Nevertheless, a strategy may be utilized again. My apprentice was the crux of this trap, though he did not know it. I am afraid I have little time to risk myself in battle, General Shivertail. It is my children you fight today. And it is they who will claim your life."

That *voice*. Zel snarled, twisting around. But the Necromancer wasn't here. He was speaking through his minions.

"Too afraid I'll kill you a second time?"

Again the undead servants rustled. Az'kerash had called them his children? What had he done in the years since the Second Antinium War?

"Hardly. My battle was never with one individual. I wage war with Drakes, with species as a whole. The living are my enemy, Shivertail. You do not merit my presence. My creations are enough for you. Each one is a masterpiece, unique among their kind. Look upon them and despair, for they are your betters."

"So you say. But you sent five."

Again, Zel studied the undead. They had names; they had some kind of personality—were they Revenants? Spirits bound to flesh? Yes, they had to be. But two of them bothered Zel. Ijvani—he could have sworn he'd seen that *staff* before. Zel's eyes widened as he recognized it.

"Imenet."

The flames in the skeleton's eyes flashed at Zel's voice, and Venitra shifted. The Necromancer's voice was amused.

“Yes. You encountered Venitra and Ijvani before. A shame neither one managed to accomplish their tasks. Tell me, how did you realize I was still alive? It seems you were...informed of my survival before now.”

His voice was...probing. Zel lied as he tried to think. The bone walls were meant to hold him. Cutting his way out while the undead attacked from behind was suicide.

“It wasn’t hard to figure out. Your illusion spells aren’t as potent as you thought. And you have enemies.”

“Only naturally. But was it Magnolia Reinhart who told you I was alive, or someone else? I had suspected she was aware of my deception. Did she warn you about me, or had you known before that?”

There was a pressure in the air that made Zel want to talk about Ryoka. Truth spells. He bit his tongue and focused on the other undead. Ijvani was one thing. But Kerash? The undead Gnoll was clearly the leader, but there was something else about him.

Draugr weren’t too dangerous to Zel. They were strong, but there was a limit to their strength. They couldn’t exceed the capability of their bodies in life. So unless this Gnoll had been particularly powerful, he wasn’t as dangerous as, say, Venitra. But that *name*—

“Are you really Kerash, the Gnoll Warrior-Chieftain who died over a hundred years ago?”

Zel addressed Kerash. The Gnoll shifted his grip on his sword, his eyes never leaving Zel’s face.

“I am my master’s loyal servant. That is all you need to know before you die, Drake.”

“Well spoken, first of my Chosen.”

Az'kerash's voice was approving. Zel's eyes narrowed. So. Kerash. That might be...his eyes flicked again to the five undead. What were they? Assassins? Vanguard? But why have them at all?

"Children, you said? You created these horrors, Necromancer? That's strangely sentimental for someone who uses the undead as disposable tools."

"Hardly. These are my champions, my chosen few. They are created to be superior to all other undead, to lead and instill despair among my foes. You gave me the idea for them, in fact. After my defeat and 'death' in the last war I reflected on my weaknesses. These five, my Chosen, are my answer to that flaw."

An answer to a flaw? But the Necromancer's greatest weakness was—Zel's eyes widened. He murmured out loud as the pieces fell into place.

"So *that's* why you made them. I see. They truly are your masterpieces. Your...hope. And if I crush them, your plans are set back, aren't they?"

There was a pause. Az'kerash's voice did not reply. Zel smiled as the undead shifted. When the Necromancer did speak, there was a twinge, the slightest hint of uncertainty in his voice.

"Enough of this! Kerash, finish Zel Shivertail off."

"Yes, Master. Everyone, on my mark. Attack as one."

Kerash's voice rumbled as he gripped his sword with both hands. Venitra raised her shield and both Oom and Bea took a step forwards. Oom's hands were in the pockets of his coat; Bea's rotting palms were turned towards Zel. Ijvani raised her staff.

Silence. The five undead and one Drake waited. For one eternal, immortal moment, there was nothing but the pumping of Zel's heart, the burning eyes of the undead. Then he saw Kerash's mouth open. Zel moved

before the undead could speak. He sprinted *right*, into Venitra and Ijvani and slashed.

“*[Lightning Slash]!*”

Ijvani cried out as Zel raked a claw across her arms and ribs, slicing across her black bones. Zel grunted as he hit her bones—they were metal, or coated with it! He recalled the same sensation as when he’d fought her the first time. But his slash had cut deep across her ribs and sent her stumbling back. Zel turned and saw Venitra rushing at him, ready to stab.

“*[Bonebreaker Headbutt]!*”

Another Skill. Zel stepped forwards and smashed his head into Venitra’s. He heard a *crack*, and saw her stumble back. Zel whirled, and sidestepped as Kerash charged him with his sword. Zel kicked and the Gnoll stumbled. He would have leapt on Kerash and torn the sword from his hands, but Oom and Bea were on his left, and Zel moved away rather than let either get close to him. They were just approaching. Were their attacks touch-based?

He turned, looking for Venitra, and saw a black, skeletal hand. Ijvani pointed with her staff and uttered a spell.

“*[Blackfire Fireball].*”

And then there was flame. Zel *roared* as the flames engulfed his body, burning every exposed part of him not covered by armor. He struck at Ijvani but she was already fleeing. And then Venitra crashed into his left, stabbing. Zel stumbled, regained his footing, and pushed back as she tried to bowl him over.

The two titans struggled as Oom and Bea circled. And then Kerash was closing in with his sword. He stabbed Zel in the arm as the Drake fought.

The [General] turned and roared again. But he was alone. And outnumbered.

“Bring down that dome!”

Sacra screamed the order and over a hundred [Mages] blasted the dome with spells from afar. Humans, a few half-Elves, and Goblins. Both armies were trying to crack the shields of bone, although the Goblins had switched to a defensive strategy to keep the Humans from nearing their Lord’s last line of defense.

Or so they assumed. Magnolia knew this had to be the work of the Necromancer. She stared as the rain of spells and enchanted arrows ceased.

“Nothing. Not a scratch.”

The bombardment hadn’t left a mark on the ivory surface, just cleaned it of the Goblin blood staining the outside.

“It’s impenetrable! Focus your attacks elsewhere! I want covering fire on our [Knights]! Take down that Crypt Lord!”

Sacra ordered the [Mages] to begin targeting Goblins. Magnolia knew it was the correct decision, but she would have rather kept trying to bring down the dome. Zel Shivertail could be in peril—

No, he *was* in peril! She knew it. Magnolia cursed, and saw a shape flick into the shadows behind her.

“Ressa, give me the weapon.”

Magnolia raised her hands and Ressa put the strange tube that her grandfather had given her into her hands without argument. The [Maid]

stood behind Magnolia, her maid's uniform covered in blood.

“Are you sure?”

“Zel Shivertail *cannot* be lost! Hold on, I'm aiming!”

Magnolia snapped as she raised the tube. She was no [Markswoman], but the dome was a big target and she felt like accuracy was not a requirement. She hesitated as she felt the magic contained in the artifact.

“How did grandfather Regis say to activate it? What was the command spell? *Thaurmodesium*?”

“*Thaurmodenasium*!”

“Yes, that! *Thaurmodenasium*! By my command, fire or—”

Magnolia felt the tube warm slightly, felt it kick in her hands, and heard nothing.

Precisely nothing. A cone of silence had burst from the tube. Magnolia felt it leave her hands and stepped back as the tube floated in place. It was a simple metal tube, inscribed with glowing runes on the inside and outside. Now these same runes glowed brighter and brighter, so brightly that they became a beacon.

Heads turned. Goblins and Humans alike gaped as the tube glowed, and then emitted a series of—sparks. A few paltry sparks jettisoned out of the front of the tube. Magnolia stared as they flickered forwards and turned to Ressa.

“Is that it? Because if it is, I'm going to the family estate and burning it down—”

Ressa gripped Magnolia's arm and pointed. Magnolia turned her head back just in time to see the sparks of lightning continue forwards. They

were just flickering bits of energy, but for some reason, they neither earthed themselves nor dissipated. Instead, they hung in the air, and changed.

They became...diverse. Or perhaps they created more copies of themselves, because the air was suddenly dancing with bolts of lightning. They played over the Goblins and Humans in front of the tube, making the soldiers yelp and drop their metallic weapons. And then, from the tube, there came more lightning.

It was like lightning had come to life. Magnolia stared as a *dragon* made out of lightning took wing, emerging from the tube and flying forwards. She saw ships made of lightning, proud warriors and [Knights]—it was a light show! The lightning danced over the heads of both the Human and Goblin armies, making soldiers look up in awe. And as the Dragon soared overhead, doing absolutely no damage to the Goblin army, it left a trail of words in the sky.

The script was elegant, cursive, and hard to read. It was a different writing script than Magnolia had ever seen, but ancient as it was, it was still perfectly legible.

From the armories of the Emperor of Storms: a gift. To his enemies, see light and sound, ever fleeting, the wrath of the skies. Behold the advent of lightning.

And then there was light from the front of the tube. Magnolia blinked at it. The opening of the tube glowed and that was the last thing she saw for a while. She felt the *impact* as the air shattered, though. It threw her backwards and only Ressa catching her saved Magnolia from breaking her neck.

A bolt, a beam, a *cascade* of lightning burst forth from the mouth of the tube, cutting through the bemused ranks of Goblin soldiers and some of the Humans too close to the radius of the blast. The lightning did not fry those it touched—rather, it vaporized them. It left a trail of melted ground and smoke around fifteen feet wide as it shot across the battlefield. It hit the bone of dome—

And cracked it open. The bone splintered, the Necromancer’s magic broken. For a second, Ressa could see six shapes struggling in the darkness—then the magic of the lightning flashed around the opening. It obscured the rest, as the tube earthed its charge on the dome of bone.

It had been broken open, but as the shock of the spell reverberated across the battlefield she could see the walls of bone shudder and begin closing. The spell was reassembling itself.

“No! Get in there! *War Golems, go to General Shivertail’s aid!*”

Magnolia struggled to get up. She thrust away Ressa’s hands and stumbled upright. Her ears were bleeding, her vision still blinded. Still she pointed. And the War Golems, cutting through the Goblins, turned.

They charged, shrieking, racing across the ground. Goblins raced to stop them, screaming. The first War Golem blasted them with a beam of fire. The second blasted the rest with lightning, far less powerful than that of Magnolia’s artifact, but still strong enough to shock and kill.

“*Go, go!*”

Magnolia screamed the words, Ressa holding her back. Across the battlefield, the Goblins were screaming the opposite.

“Stop them!”

Snapjaw raced at the second Golem, seeing Goblins with chains and rope trying to slow it. But the massive beast was unstoppable. She grabbed a chain and felt herself being dragged along. Lightning blasted her, travelling down the chain. Snapjaw felt her body shaking, saw flashes—she hung on.

Goblins seized her from behind. Two more Hobs grabbed a chain. Snapjaw saw them jerk as they held on. One Hob spasmed—she could see him dying as he held the chain. His heart—hers was fluttering, stopping. Still, they dug their heels in the mud.

“*Stop!*”

The Goblins had formed a chain twenty bodies deep on each rope, but the War Golem had only slowed. It was still moving forwards. Still moving —

A shape blocked its way. Eater of Spears roared as he charged into the War Golem. He swung a fist and the massive metal monster punched back. Its dagger-fingers sank into the giant Hobgoblin’s stomach, tore. Eater of Spears roared in pain and Snapjaw tried to drag the War Golem back.

The rift in the walls of bone was closing! They just had to hold the Golem—hold it—

Snapjaw wasn’t sure when the next bolt of lightning stopped her heart. She saw everything flash—found herself lying on her back. She sat upright, saw the Golem pounding Eater of Spears down. Saw him hold on to its legs.

The first Golem was at the opening. It pushed inside as the bone began to flow around it. The second threw aside Eater of Spears and raced for the opening. It crashed into the gap, made it halfway inside—and lodged in place. The bone covered it, entrapping the struggling Golem. It fought, and

then, slowly, began to die. The magical dome was crushing its insides, bending the enchanted metal of its body. The Golem stopped moving and Snapjaw saw the bright light in its mouth dim and go out.

It was dead. But one of the Golems had entered. Snapjaw hoped it would be enough. But she had no idea what was going on inside. She only knew her Goblin Lord was alive.

The rest was a mystery.

Zel Shivertail was alone. He had been alone before. But never like this.

The undead surrounded him. Venitra cut at his left—Kerash his right. Zel blocked with his arm and leg. Both blades bit into his flesh. He roared and slashed at Kerash—a wall of oozing gelatin blocked him.

“Eat him, Oom!”

Bea cried out, circling Zel, afraid to get cut by his claws. Oom extended his ‘arm’, letting Zel’s claws sink further into his body. The Drake roared as he felt his scales *burning* and yanked his arm out.

“My second eldest creation, Oom. He was made to destroy you, Shivertail.”

Az’kerash’s voice was calm as the undead continued their attack. Ijvani blasted Zel with a spray of something black that tried to obscure his vision—he blocked it with his hand, and kicked at Venitra as she charged. But the bone woman was so *heavy*—her body was solid bone and the momentum of her charge carried her into him. She knocked Zel over and he grunted as her sword stabbed towards his head.

“Not—”

He threw her off her with all the strength he could manage. A sword stabbed at his breastplate and failed to penetrate his armor. Kerash slashed at Zel’s head and again the Drake blocked with an arm as he rose. More blood—another cut—the blade was terribly, terribly cold, but Zel could handle the pain.

What was worse was Oom. The undead creature had tangled around his legs, engulfing them. Zel tried to break free, and failed. Ijvani scorched him with another fireball made of black flames.

“Slimes! It’s not undead, it’s a damned—”

Zel roared as Oom tried to engulf him. He swung a fist and part of Oom’s body sprayed outwards, but the rest kept sticking to his body. The Necromancer’s voice was amused.

“Indeed. An Acid Slime, given sentience and far more power of course. It is rare for such a creature to form naturally, but a simple matter for me. Oom is your natural enemy, Shivertail.”

The acid was burning Zel, and if Oom covered his mouth, he’d be in Zel’s insides, suffocating him. Zel *heaved* and part of Oom splattered across the bone walls.

“Not yet.”

He moved his feet, but they were still stuck. Now Venitra and Kerash were on either side. Venitra swung and this time her blade cut *deep* into Zel’s arm. He staggered and Kerash sliced into his leg. Both blades hit bone.

Falling. Zel felt it. He twisted, reaching for a potion at his belt, but Oom was pulling him down again, trying to hold his arms. He had to—Zel felt

more fire burning him, opened his mouth and felt it scorching his body. And Bea was reaching for him with a rotted hand.

And then the wall exploded. Zel felt the impact, felt something lift his body, Oom, and all the undead and *throw* them into the far wall. He slid to the ground, stunned, and then got up.

“What—”

There was *daylight!* Something had blown open the wall of the dome! Zel saw shocked Goblin faces turning towards him and heard the Necromancer’s voice.

“How—what artifact was—*Kerash! Do not let Shivertail escape!*”

His voice was urgent. Kerash and Venitra threw themselves in the way of the gap. Zel charged and his fist collided with Venitra’s shield. For the first time in that battle, Zel ran up against something he couldn’t push back. Venitra struck at him with her sword and he dodged left. The gap was closing! Zel ran at Kerash, not caring if he took a blade to get out—

And then Oom abandoned his trench coat. He surged out of his clothing and into the gap, creating a wall out of his body. The slime formed a wall and the undead created a wall in front of him. Zel halted. He stared at the undead and thought for a second.

Then he backed up. Kerash stared and Venitra lifted her sword uncertainly. She took a step forwards, but too late. Zel had a potion at his belt and was downing it.

“Stop him!”

Ijvani tried to cast a spell, but Zel sidestepped the bolts of lightning. The undead wavered, but if they moved they would have to abandon the closing gap to the outside. Grimly, Zel downed two more potions, feeling his wounds close and his body surge with energy.

And the gap closed. He couldn't escape. Oom and the four other undead flowed away from the gap as it narrowed. Then Kerash's head turned.

"What is that sound? Oom?"

Zel heard a *shriek*. The slime turned—and was splattered as one of Magnolia's two War Golems surged into the gap. It turned, its glowing mouth appraising, and immediately slashed at Kerash. The undead scattered.

The gap in the ivory walls closed. Zel saw another Golem racing at the opening, saw it get caught—he was already leaping at Ijvani.

"Golem, cover me!"

He roared at the War Golem as it slashed at Venitra and Kerash. The two warrior-undead scattered to either side, blocking the Golem's sharp dagger-fingers and cutting at its legs. Both their blades cut into the Golem's enchanted body more easily than Zel's flesh.

"Help me!"

Ijvani screamed at the other undead as Zel savaged her with his claws. He was trying to destroy her head, but her bones were tough and she was blocking with her staff. He ripped one arm off and then felt a cold stickiness engulf his left arm. His scales began to burn at the same time.

"Oom! Hold him so I can touch him!"

Bea dashed forwards. Zel kicked at her and she stumbled back. She was the least agile of the undead. But she managed to distract him long enough—Oom finally managed to engulf Zel's torso.

"Finish him, Oom!"

Kerash roared as he cut at the Golem's legs. The Golem was on its knees—it couldn't handle the onslaught of both undead at once. Zel saw its

mouth glowing red and shouted.

“Golem—fire on *me!*”

The War Golem looked up. It focused on Zel and he saw a fiery inferno grow in its mouth. The fiery laser erupted from its mouth and blasted Zel and Oom as they stood locked in place.

“*Oom!*”

Bea screamed. The undead woman lurched forwards. Too late. The slime *screamed*, a soundless wail as the fire blasted its body apart. Zel felt Oom’s body vaporize around him. He stumbled, felt his scales flaking off. But his hands were reaching. Where—

There. He found a core in the slime’s body. A mana stone, his heart. It was large, as large as Zel’s fist. Oom’s gelatinous body wriggled around it, burning Zel, trying to infiltrate his body, burn it. Zel gripped the stone tightly.

All four undead were staring at him. Bea raised one hand. Her eyes were wide. Why had Az’kerash made her so much like a normal Human woman? Her voice shook.

“Don’t—”

Zel’s grip tightened. Oom *screamed* as the mana stone broke. And then there was silence.

The slime dripped from Zel’s body as he stood. The Drake swung his arm and the acid that had been Oom’s body splattered across the ground. He tossed the shattered mana stone to the ground and looked around.

The War Golem collapsed as Kerash drove his enchanted blade into the back of its head. Venitra rose, her shield smoking after having blocked a second fiery beam. The four undead stared at Zel Shivertail.

He was burned. His arms screamed—he could feel his bones were cracked in places, feel the acid eating at him. But still Zel stood. He looked around at them, the confident undead, now, suddenly aware of their mortality.

“That’s one. Who’s next?”

“Oom.”

Az’kerash’s voice was a hiss. Kerash raised his sword as he and Venitra flanked Zel again.

“You will pay for that.”

Venitra’s voice was deep. Zel laughed at her.

“Venitra, don’t rush in!”

Kerash stopped Venitra before the bone woman could charge at him. The Gnoll pointed.

“Ijvani, lock down the Drake’s movements. Venitra, cover me.”

He advanced, sword at the ready. Zel gritted his teeth as Ijvani tossed a spell at him. It was some kind of ooze—like Oom it stuck to whatever it touched. He got some on his leg as he pivoted to dodge—Kerash slashed at Zel’s eyes and was blocked. Venitra charged with her shield and Zel scored her twice across the chest with his claws. He could cut her body! But the strikes weren’t deep and the impact jarred his hands. Zel snarled, raised his claws.

“[Rending—]”

And Bea touched his body.

It was quick, just a touch on his arm. But the instant her pallid flesh made contact with his, Zel felt a hot flash run down his arm. And then—a

terrible uneasiness.

He whirled, seeing Bea's hand stretched towards him. The undead woman had lunged at him, ignoring the danger. Zel's claw took off her arm as she tried to retreat. But the second touch felt just as bad as the first. And as Bea stepped back there was a sense of...satisfaction in her eyes.

"What was—that?"

Zel sensed the other undead moving back. He grabbed at his belt and shattered a potion bottle as he smashed it over his arm. The liquid splashed across the spots Bea had touched him at. But instead of healing the spots she'd touched, the burning sensation ran down Zel's arm. And—pain.

"Excellent job, Bea."

Az'kerash's voice sounded satisfied again. Bea picked up her arm and retreated. The undead watched Zel as he clutched at his arm. His arm and his claws hurt. Whatever the burning was, it was spreading like wildfire. Why? Because of the touch?

No, because of the potion. Zel realized his mistake too late. Healing potions healed most things, but they weren't cure-alls. They couldn't regenerate lost limbs, and they could only heal what a normal person could be expected to get through. That was because they amplified a body's healing process, made it faster. And while that worked on damaged flesh and bone, it didn't work on—

"Plague."

Bea spoke the words mockingly. Zel coughed, and stared at the blood on his claws. His lungs burned as the magical disease coursed through his body. He looked around. The undead grinned at him. Four pairs of mocking eyes. Zel closed his and straightened.

Then he smiled. The undead hesitated. Zel opened his claws as he tossed his belt and the healing potions to the ground. He nodded to them, and clenched one fist.

“Well then. Let’s end this, shall we?”

He charged Venitra first, ignoring the blade she stabbed into his side. His claws were sharp. And there was nothing holding him back anymore.

The battle had been long. The battle had been short. To the Goblin Lord, it felt as though the battle between Zel Shivertail and the undead had gone on forever. He knew it couldn’t have been more than...no, how long had it been?

Five minutes? Ten minutes? Twenty minutes? Half an hour? It continued. Zel Shivertail whirled, striking left and right, refusing to let the undead regroup. They had burned him, cut him, smashed his bones, poisoned him, infected him—and yet he stood.

The Goblin Lord had seen it all. He had lain where Zel had fallen, clinging to life with his own magics as the undead and the Drake battled. Now, he desperately uncorked a healing potion, one of the ones Zel had dropped and poured it over his stomach.

His organs began to heal. The Goblin Lord pushed them into his stomach, trying not to scream as Zel cut at Venitra. The Drake [General] was gasping, his green scales mottled with the disease as it spread unnaturally fast. Part of his body was simply black with ash and soot—his scales were flaking off. Yet still he attacked. Venitra raised her shield as the claws slashed across them. Zel hit her with a punch that cracked her pristine face.

“You dare—”

She cried out in outrage as fracture lines ran from one cheek. Venitra swung her sword and Zel grabbed it.

“*Weak!*”

He roared as he yanked the blade away. Venitra abandoned her shield and raised a massive fist. She swung and Zel punched. The Drake’s fist shattered her nose. His next blow cracked her bone chest plate.

The Drake lifted Venitra, her entire massive body, and *threw* her at Bea, who’d been sneaking up on him from behind. The blow sent both female undead tumbling to the ground and Bea’s body broke as Venitra landed on her. Zel turned and Kerash’s sword lanced into his shoulder. Zel’s slash opened the Gnoll’s chest, exposing his ribs.

“[Blackfire Fireball]!”

Ijvani fired the same spell again, engulfing Zel in flames, giving Kerash a second to retreat. Zel turned, his body blazing, and *kicked* Ijvani. The skeleton broke into pieces and crashed to the ground. Venitra struggled to her feet and Az’kerash’s voice spoke in the silence as Zel paused a moment to gasp for air.

“Still?”

The Goblin Lord could hear Zel’s lungs wheezing for air. The Drake took a step towards Kerash and stumbled. The Gnoll backed up. His chest hung open, the dead flesh severed. Venitra raised her shield unsteadily.

“Hold.”

The undead paused. Az’kerash’s voice was sharp as Zel coughed more blood up.

“[Flesh Regrowth]. [Mend Bones]. Venitra, support Kerash! Your role is to take his blows, not charge in alone! Ijvani, advance! Use more powerful spells to decimate the area—the other three will survive your magic! Bea, attempt to find the Drake’s back!”

“He’s still standing, Master! He shouldn’t be—he should be *dead* by now!”

Bea cried out as she circled Zel. The Drake turned to face her, his eyes burning. He was slowing though. The Goblin Lord could see it. And yet, it was Zel who made the first move. He slashed at Bea, cutting into her stomach as she leapt back. Again, the contact with her body made whatever infection that was coursing through Zel intensify, but he ignored the spreading stain on his claws. He stood and beckoned at the other undead as they circled him warily.

“Come on. Come *on*! I thought you were supposed to be monsters!”

His eyes blazed beneath the blood and burnt scales on his face. Again, the four hesitated. But they attacked as one, moving in perfect unison.

Venitra low, Kerash high. Bea from the left, Ijvani from the back. Zel cut Kerash and seized Venitra’s head. He *twisted* and the bones forming her neck began to crack.

“*Weak!*”

Again Zel roared the word. Venitra managed to loosen his grip on her and stumbled back. The undead retreated as Zel swung at Ijvani, staring. Zel stumbled.

“You cannot win this battle, Shivertail. I am impressed you are still standing. But—”

“Four left.”

Zel regained his balance and grabbed Kerash's blade as it swung at his head. His claws bled as the enchanted metal dug into his claws. He hit Kerash in the face, bashing the Gnoll's face in. Kerash stumbled back. Bea leapt at Zel and he kicked her. The tip of his foot pierced her abdomen and he stomped her to the ground. She gasped.

"Your minions can't kill me."

Zel rasped as he ground Bea's body underneath his foot. She was grabbing at his leg and he was ignoring it. Venitra and Kerash attacked with Ijvani, but Zel refused to budge.

"You think you understand strength! I am the shield of the Drakes! I am a [General]! *And a general does not fall!*"

He bent and cut Bea in two. She gasped and stared at her lower half, separate from her torso. Zel turned.

"Three!"

He charged into Venitra, trading blows with the bone knight. It was she who fell back, cracked and broken. Zel ignored Kerash as the Gnoll cut at his back. And the Goblin Lord moved.

Slowly, ever so slowly he rose. His body was weak, and he had no more magic for a spell. But Venitra had dropped her sword as Zel continued his assault. The bone blade was heavy, but strong. The Goblin Lord grabbed it stealthily.

"Drake!"

Kerash was dueling Zel as Venitra fell to one knee. He was falling back—Ijvani was cowering, her body nearly torn to bits. The Goblin Lord crept up on Zel from behind, sword raised. He aimed for Zel's neck as the Drake beat Kerash down with blows that cracked the undead Gnoll's shoulders and arms. Wait...Zel's claws were on Kerash's head. He began to twist—

Now. The Goblin Lord leapt forwards. Zel turned, fast as a snake. He *kicked* the Goblin Lord and the Goblin felt his ribs crumple from the blow. He fell, gasping, as Zel flung Kerash backwards.

“Idiot.”

He coughed more blood out as he kicked the Goblin Lord before he could go for the sword again. Kerash stumbled up—Zel’s fist cracked his skull.

“Now.”

The Drake [General] was slowing, but he still charged Venitra as she came at him. The two grappled, desperate, Venitra’s body breaking. The Goblin Lord tried to get up. He grabbed the sword and slashed at Zel’s legs. The Drake grunted as the blade pierced his thigh. He turned, grabbed the Goblin Lord, and raised a claw as he shoved Venitra back. The undead woman stumbled, and the Goblin Lord looked into Zel’s eyes.

“I—”

Someone moved behind the Goblin Lord. He saw Zel’s eyes widen, felt the Drake release him. Too slow.

“[Diamondshard Spray].”

A hand rose and pointed. The Goblin Lord felt something flash past his face—tear through one of his ears. Zel stumbled. Glittering shards of diamond shot through the air, some as long as daggers, tearing into his face, his body. The Drake turned towards Az’kerash as the Necromancer raised his hands. He moved.

“[Accelerate Spell]. [Stone Lance].”

Zel’s head twisted. The Goblin Lord saw a flash, felt the impact on the far wall as the lance of stone broke. And as Zel Shivertail turned his head

back, the Goblin Lord saw part of his head was missing.

“[Deathblast].”

Again, the Necromancer pointed. This time the black magic that washed over Zel was a wave, far stronger than anything the Goblin Lord could create. It sapped the last of the Drake’s energy, rendered his body stiff. Az’kerash pointed at the Drake’s chest and uttered the spell again.

“[Deathblast].”

The dark magic struck Zel. He stumbled, his leg moved—stopped. He stood in place, eyes vacant.

“[Deathblast].”

There was no light in his eyes. The Goblin Lord wanted to cry out. Treachery! He had attacked from behind! But that was how Goblins fought. And yet the Necromancer...Az’kerash’s black eyes were locked on Zel’s own. The Drake’s gaze was unmoving.

“[Deathblast].”

The fourth spell was the last. Zel didn’t move as the spell struck him. Az’kerash lowered his finger then, and looked around.

“Ah, my apprentice. Your timing was quite useful. For that distraction, I thank you.”

The Goblin Lord stared up at his master, at Az’kerash. The Necromancer was here. *Here*. He must have used one of his Scrolls of Greater Teleport to come here. The Goblin Lord knew he had only eleven left. No—four now. He had spent those valuable artifacts for this.

For Zel Shivertail. The Necromancer turned his gaze back to the Drake. Zel Shivertail stood in place, part of his head simply...gone. He had dodged the worst of the Necromancer’s spells, but a shard of diamond had taken his

left eye. And his body was burnt black in places, cut from a thousand blades, and discolored from where Bea's plague touch had spread.

And still, he had fought through it all. And if the Necromancer had not come at the last—the Goblin Lord looked away.

“Master!”

A voice interrupted the silence. Bea crawled towards her creator, her body badly damaged. The Goblin Lord moved away from her as she dragged her torso towards Az'kerash. She was holding a broken stone in her hands.

“Ah, Bea.”

Az'kerash greeted her with obvious satisfaction in his voice. The undead woman did not share his joy. She held the pieces of Oom's mana stone in trembling hands.

“Oom! He's dead, Master. Can you—is he—”

“Gone.”

The Necromancer's voice was cold and dispassionate. Bea stared up at him, her legs separated from her body, cradling what remained of Oom.

“But he fought! Master—”

“I warned him to safeguard his mana core at all costs. He was foolish, allowing that War Golem to damage him so. No, perhaps it was Shivertail I underestimated. Or was it the capabilities of my Chosen? Venitra, Kerash, rise. I am disappointed in you both. And perhaps you most of all, Ijvani; how is it you failed to damage Zel Shivertail in any meaningful way throughout the battle?”

The other undead, the Necromancer's Chosen, began to rise, shamefaced. Venitra had to have Kerash's help to stumble upright.

“Master. We are grateful.”

Kerash’s voice rasped. Az’kerash eyed him.

“You are badly damaged, Kerash. I must restructure your body when we return to the castle. All of you. Prepare yourselves for transit. I will destroy the enchantment protecting this place momentarily. Ijvani, you will make your way back with an invisibility spell; there are no more scrolls of teleportation.”

“Yes, *Master*.”

The Goblin Lord stared at the black skeleton as she stumbled away from the others. Bea still pleaded with her master.

“Master, what if I took the fragments back? If I put it in Oom’s special place, maybe—”

“He is *gone*, Bea.”

Az’kerash’s eyes flashed with annoyance and the undead woman shrank back. He turned, his face displeased, and then relented as he looked towards Zel again.

“Ah, General Shivertail. What a formidable opponent you were. Perhaps if you had been a touch faster in battle, or escaped Bea’s touch a moment sooner, I might have reconsidered arriving myself. But for all your strength in life, you will be the finest of my servants in death. For that, I thank you.”

He walked over to Zel, his hands reaching out to touch the Drake’s chest. The Goblin Lord saw Zel’s eyes flicker, saw the Drake’s claws move.

“*[Antimagic Slash]!*”

The cut was fast. It scythed through the almost-invisible aura of protection around the Necromancer’s body, cut into his neck—but only just. Zel was too far away. His claws only opened the Necromancer’s throat. And

as the Necromancer staggered back, his black eyes wide with shock, Zel collapsed.

“What—”

The Necromancer’s throat did not bleed. He covered his pale flesh and stared at Zel. The Drake looked up at him, fallen, unable to move. Just looked.

“Return! Apprentice, finish the Drake! Secure his corpse!”

Az’kerash’s voice snapped. He grabbed for a scroll at his side and vanished. The undead around him stared at their master—Ijvani disappeared in a pop as she cast [Lesser Teleport] and the others fled, pulling out scrolls of their own. The Goblin Lord looked around, stunned by the sudden absence of the other undead.

“Hah. Hahaha. Coward.”

Zel Shivertail lay on the ground, laughing. He was still alive. Somehow. The Goblin Lord could see into his head, but the Drake still clung to life. His eyes turned to the Goblin Lord.

“I’m sorry.”

The Goblin Lord said it as he knelt by Zel’s side. He stared down at the Drake, seeing how the enchanted armor had failed in places. The magical metal had been melted in one place, pierced in two. Zel Shivertail stared up at the ivory ceiling overhead. The enchantment was breaking up—the dome was collapsing in places, letting sunlight in.

The Goblin Lord could hear Humans and Goblins shouting outside the dome in confusion. There was still a battle going on. But in this moment he only had eyes for Zel. He felt he should say something.

“I’m sorry. It was not a worthy death. Cowardly. It was—”

He got no further. A hand shot out and grabbed him by the throat. The Goblin Lord choked, tried to move back. He couldn't. Zel Shivertail sat up, his grip crushing the Goblin Lord's throat.

"I'm not dead yet."

He stared at the Goblin Lord with his one good eye. It blazed with a strange light. How could he still move? How could he—the Goblin Lord was choking.

"I could kill you. It would be so easy."

Zel Shivertail said the words casually. He stared at the Goblin Lord, and then, suddenly, released him. The Goblin Lord stumbled backwards, gasping for air.

"I don't feel like it. Not anymore."

Zel stared ahead. His head was—blood dripped from the missing part of his head. His voice was distant.

"I feel so tired. So this is how it ends? Funny, I always thought it would be—quicker."

He turned his head. The Goblin Lord stared at him. But Zel was no longer looking at him. The Drake [General] looked ahead, and his voice was very distant.

"Sserys, old friend. I couldn't lead them. I couldn't inspire them like you did. But I tried. I wonder, would you say this was a job well done? I couldn't kill the Necromancer, in the end. I only got one of his minions. And..."

His voice trailed off. Zel's head drooped. His voice was lower. The Goblin Lord moved forwards to hear. Zel's voice was a whisper as he looked ahead, looked at the past.

“My mentor, my friend, wings of my heart, did I do a good job? Defending our people? It was so very difficult without you. Will I see you, I wonder? Will you say I did a good job or a bad one when we meet?”

“You did.”

The Goblin Lord spoke, his voice trembling. He reached out, hesitated. He spoke, as gently as he could.

“You did. You protected them. Your people. You did it. It was a good job.”

Zel stirred. His eyes focused on the Goblin Lord’s face and he frowned.

“I’ll let Sserys tell me in person, Goblin.”

He stared at the Goblin, and then smiled. It was such a strange thing that the Goblin Lord nearly smiled back. The Goblin brushed at his eyes and was surprised to find water on his claws. Zel looked at him.

“Do you have a name?”

“No. No name. Just Goblin Lord. Apprentice. Goblin.”

The Goblin Lord sat next to Zel as the dome broke. The Drake looked up at the sky. He sighed.

“How strange. Everyone should have a name. It doesn’t seem right. You—should have one.”

The Goblin Lord was silent. Zel stared up, blood dripping slowly from his wounds. And then stopped.

“How about Reiss? It’s a proper Drake name. If I had a son—Sserys always talked about wanting to raise a boy and name him that.”

Reiss. The Goblin Lord stared at Zel for a second. The Drake laughed.

“Take it if you want it. I don’t think Sserys will mind. And—no, never mind.”

“I will. And I will avenge. Avenge you and my people. I swear it. The Necromancer will die by my hand.”

The Goblin Lord looked at Zel. The Drake eyed him, and then shrugged.

“Good. I hope you do it. But I won’t be around to see it. And truthfully...I would have liked to...”

His voice trailed off. Reiss looked into Zel’s eyes and saw that the Drake’s vision had gone distant again. Zel whispered as the Goblin Lord wiped at his eyes again.

“A good job. Did I do it?”

He laughed once.

“I suppose I’ll never know. But I did try. I did—”

Reiss waited a long time, but Zel never finished his sentence. He sat there, the last traces of laughter still on his face. The Tidebreaker stared up at the sky as the walls of ivory finally broke and both armies could see into the dome at last.

There was just silence at first. Reiss sat with Zel, head bowed, until he realized that it looked like both he and Zel were dead. He stood slowly, and heard the Goblins roaring. But from the Human side there was no noise.

There was only silence. Then the Goblin Lord heard a groan from the Humans. It sounded like something living had been torn from them. He saw the armored ranks of men and women falter, saw some fall to their knees and others begin to weep. The news dawned on the army slowly as they saw the Goblin Lord standing over the distant form of their [General].

Zel Shivertail was dead. The Tidebreaker had fallen.

And the Goblin Lord had slain him.

It was not the truth. Reiss wanted to scream it out loud. But he couldn't. And the Goblins roared as they saw the fallen Drake and their victorious leader. They streamed towards him, screaming, staring in awe at the fallen Zel Shivertail.

“Dead! Dead, dead, *dead!*”

Snapjaw shouted the words in triumph. She and the other Goblins were fighting to get to the Goblin Lord, offering potions. One Goblin reached to push Zel Shivertail aside. Reiss whirled and shouted.

“*Stop!*”

The Goblins froze. The Goblin Lord looked around and pointed to Zel Shivertail's body.

“Leave body. Anyone who touches, dies.”

They stared at him, and then at the fallen Drake. Reiss wiped at his eyes. He said one word.

“Withdraw.”

He turned and walked away. Uncomprehending, the Goblins stared at him and then followed. Reiss the Goblin Lord led his army away as the Humans stared at the slumped figure in shining armor. They wept, and the cry went up. It echoed across the battlefield, across the city of Invisil, and out onto the rest of the continent. The words shook the world.

Magnolia Reinhart wept as she retreated from the battlefield. Ressa, beside her, was dry-eyed, but her hands were tight on her mistress' arm as she guided Magnolia away. Lady Reinhart spoke only once as they retreated behind the procession bearing the Tidebreaker's body away from the battle.

"I am offering a hundred thousand gold coins. No, I will offer a *million* gold coins or whatever artifacts I own. Spread the word among the Assassin's Guilds, in every part of the world. I will have the Necromancer *dead*, Ressa."

"Yes, milady."

Az'kerash strode through his castle, his damaged servants, his Chosen, trailing after him. They were four now, and they dared not speak to him. The Necromancer had triumphed today, but that victory was hollow as well.

"Oom's death was unfortunate."

That was all Az'kerash said as he halted in front of his rooms. The four undead looked at him. Bea's face was a mask of grief. The Necromancer looked at each of them and then away.

"I see I have overestimated your capabilities. Or perhaps underestimated that of my foes. The next generation of your brothers and sisters will lack your weaknesses."

They bowed their heads. Az'kerash turned.

"I will repair you all shortly. Rest, and regain your strength. I have need of you yet. I have eliminated one of my greatest foes today."

He turned and smiled bitterly. And from his castle, the same words were repeated. They broke upon the Walled Cities, and shattered the hearts of the Drakes. The end of a legend. The death of an era.

Fear for the future.

The news struck Liscor like a wave. Grief-stricken Drakes stood in the streets, weeping, and the Gnolls were little better. Zel Shivertail was dead. The hero of the Second Antinium Wars, the shield that had protected Izril for so long, had fallen.

In The Wandering Inn, Klbkch saw Erin weeping at the counter and Lyonette slumped at a table. Mrsha was howling from the top of the inn. He turned, and left the building.

Klbkch did not weep. The Antinium did not cry. He slowly walked through the streets of Liscor, hearing the horns blowing, seeing grief in every corner. He walked into the Antinium Hive and heard a hush. The Workers and Soldiers did not understand the grief and fear, yes, fear that gripped the hearts of those above.

Well, that was their nature. Klbkch descended through the tunnels, walking by memory, and came to a large room. The Queen of the Free Antinium looked down at him.

“Klbkchhezeim.”

“My Queen. Has the artifact been installed to your satisfaction?”

“So it seems. The Courier delivered it to the door of the Hive this morning. I have placed it here.”

The Queen indicated a mirror made out of black glass, a tall frame that was far too small to reflect her entire body. Klbkch stared at it. It did not fit in this room, but it was a powerful artifact and there were few good alternatives.

“Have you activated it yet?”

“No.”

The Queen of the Free Antinium stared at Klbkch as he slowly walked over to the mirror. He placed a hand on it and the surface rippled. It changed. Instead of reflecting the Queen and Klbkch, the surface swam until it was reflecting another room.

It was quite similar to the one Klbkch stood in. The only difference was that this room was carved of stone, and there were quite a number of tunnels leading to and from this cavernous room. And the Queen in the center was far larger than the Queen of the Free Antinium. She was massive, bloated, and rested on a huge dais in the center of the room. She stared towards the mirror.

“Klbkchhezeim? The connection is strong it seems. How fares the Free Antinium?”

“Zel Shivertail is dead.”

Klbkch’s voice was flat. The Grand Queen of the Antinium went still. In the frame, Klbkch saw one of the Antinium gathered around her turn. Xrn stared at him. The Grand Queen was silent as she stared at Klbkch. Then her mandibles parted and rose.

“Good. We have much to do, Klbkchhezeim, my Queen of the Free Antinium.”

She waved a languid feeler. The Antinium turned to face Klbkch, and the Grand Queen spoke.

“The Goblins are moving once more. The Humans stir for war. The Drakes have lost their shield. And the Antinium will rise.”

Klbkch nodded. He stared at the Grand Queen of the Antinium, and his hands tightened on the hilts of his swords. He said only one word.

“Perhaps.”

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Author's Note:

Book 6 of The Wandering Inn is done. As always, I think it's time for a retrospective on when it was published.

This e-book and audiobook will have launched at the end of Volume 8, as The Wandering Inn is hovering close to ten million words long. By now, there's a lot of story not yet published as e-books or audiobooks.

What surprises me most, I suppose, is how fast it all feels. Six years have turned to seven in a very interesting 2021 and 2022...and I've been writing most days of the week doing this story. So it is somewhat of a live production, but the older parts of the story are also being released 'fresh' to a new audience.

I hope you've enjoyed it so far and continue to read. Each e-book is a long story by traditional standards, but the whole story is so long I'm amazed anyone reads it. Yet they do, and new readers tell me they manage it in months or weeks. Madness, but each book will hopefully be better or have something new and interesting at least. Thank you for reading and I will see you in the next book.

--pirateaba

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P I R A T E A B A

the WANDERING INN

BOOK 5

THE LAST
LIGHT

The Last Light

The Wandering Inn, Book 5

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4.00 K

The sun was setting as Flos, the King of Destruction, found the small rock outcropping at the top of the hill. He trudged up the grassy slope, admiring the greenery around him.

Despite the burning fires of the army's campfires below and the sea of tents and moving soldiers who had based themselves around the hill on which he stood, it was the grass that held more importance for Flos at this moment.

He was not accustomed to so much life in the earth. In his home, the arid ground was dry and inhospitable. The few places capable of producing water and sustenance were coveted. There would certainly be no grass growing there.

But here—Flos inhaled the smell of nature and smiled. He climbed the last stretch of hill, his armor rasping a bit as two ill-fitting pieces ground together.

“You should have that looked at, sire. I’m no [Blacksmith], but I don’t think armor is supposed to make that sound. Not unless you’re being stabbed, that is.”

The King smiled and looked up. The acerbic tone came from a man sitting on a rocky ledge, staring down at what would be tomorrow’s battlefield.

Drevish, known to all as the Architect, one of the King’s Seven, barely glanced up as Flos took a seat beside him. He was busy with a piece of parchment and charcoal. Flos glanced over his shoulder and saw the man had drawn a rough sketch of the landscape, only in his depiction there were buildings in the place of grass and stone.

“A new fortress?”

The King smiled. Drevish irritably waved him off. He continued sketching for a few moments, lost in thought. Flos was content to wait; he could see three more figures ascending the slope of the hill.

“It will not be anything special. But I want to test my new prototypes for a wall...and this place would make an acceptable chokepoint for advancing armies, or so Orthenon has informed me.”

“That it would. Assuming we take the field tomorrow.”

Flos stared pensively out across the battlefield. He could see smoke and fire rising in the distance. Drevish looked up and out at the other enemy’s encampment. He grunted sourly; the [Architect] had little time for battle.

“It escapes me why both your side and this kingdom would agree to a cease-fire overnight. Wouldn’t you customarily go down there and start hacking soldiers to bits in the night?”

“Perhaps. Fighting at night is tricky business, though. And the enemy [Commander] requested the truce.”

“And you accepted it? That seems idiotic to me.”

Drevish’s eyebrows rose, but Flos smiled. He raised his voice as he heard someone else approaching.

“They fight with honor. The [Commander] assured me not one of his soldiers would violate the terms of the truce. I took him at his word.”

“And if he lied? What if he’s marching an army to attack this camp right now, or sending another bunch of those delightful [Assassins] that have been popping up lately?”

“Well, that too would be interesting. Is this a man who believes in honor, or will he compromise it? What do you think, Amerys?”

Flos turned, and the woman who floated down out of the sky smiled at him. Amerys, the Calm Flower of the Battlefield as she was known, smiled as the flight spell let her descend next to Flos.

Drevish turned and eyed Amerys; she ignored him as she considered her King’s question.

“I think that if you gave me the order, I would be happy to attack right now. But if you want to find what this other commander is made of, why not walk in front of his camp naked and see what he does?”

Flos roared with laughter. Drevish shook his head. Muttering, he reached for a soft, round object sitting to his left. It was a kneaded eraser, something that had intrigued Flos greatly. The malleable putty could erase the charcoal from the parchment. But the old man’s hand slipped and knocked the round ball off the side of the rock.

He cursed, but a gauntleted hand caught the eraser as it fell. Gazi leapt up onto the rock, making the [Architect] jerk backwards. She smiled as she offered Drevish the eraser.

He glared at her. Drevish held out a hand and the eraser was dropped into it.

“Move. You’re blocking my view. I have little light left to work with.”

Gazi did, walking quietly over to where Flos sat. She took his right side, Amerys his left. The two didn’t quite glare at each other, but Flos knew better than to expect either to greet the other.

“So, Gazi. What have you seen?”

The half-Gazer smiled. Her central eye flicked to the enemy camp, miles away.

“I have seen several mages on the left. They are mixing with the soldiers there. Meanwhile, the cavalry is bunched up near the rear, although they pretend to occupy the right.”

“So they want to circle around and hit us from the side while the mages surprise us on the left? I’ve heard of worse plans.”

Amerys shrugged. She looked unconcerned with the upcoming battle. But the two who reached the top of the hill last were not so sanguine.

“They could be trying that Amerys, or they might know of Gazi’s eye and be baiting us. Either way, I would like to take out those mages before the battle lines are locked.”

Orthenon and a bird-man, one of the natives to this land known as Garuda, approached the group. Amerys waved a hand, Gazi smiled without turning her head as one of her eyes rolled back in its socket; Drevish just turned his head and grunted.

“Takhatres. Orthenon. Tell me one of you has brought wine or something else to drink.”

“I have brought two wine flasks. Orthenon has the cups, my lord.”

The bird man unshouldered the two bags of wine as Orthenon tossed a cup at Gazi. The [Scout] caught it without turning her head.

No one spoke for a minute. Takhatres poured wine from one flask while Orthenon did the same with the other. The Garuda advanced to the place where Drevish was sitting, and offered him a cup. The [Architect] gave him an approving grunt, and Flos accepted his cup from Orthenon with thanks.

Soon, all six people had a drink. Amerys and Drevish sipped at their drinks while the others drank faster. They didn't speak much; they didn't need to. But in the end it was Orthenon who broke the silence.

“Tomorrow, I would like Amerys to attack the left flank. If you can tie up that side, we will focus on the center and right.”

“Oh? You're not going to have me take out those mages?”

“That's my job.”

Takhatres filled his cup with more wine. He wouldn't drink more than two cups that night, Flos knew. The Garuda sipped his second cup very slowly, making his drink last.

“I will lead my kin into the left as you attack. Try not to hit us. We'll take out the mages; you just engage their front for a few minutes and then you can do what you want.”

“Fine. Try not to get in the way of my lightning.”

“Try to aim.”

Orthenon cleared his throat, looking displeased. He shifted as he knelt next to his King. Flos glanced at him and saw the single-edged sword at his

belt trailing on the rock. Orthenon was dressed for war, but it always intrigued Flos how he chose to fight.

He wasn't wearing plate armor like Flos, or Gazi's brown scale armor. Instead, he was wearing leather, form-fitting and enchanted. That was also unlike Drevish, who was wearing clothing since he wouldn't be fighting tomorrow and Takhatres, who was wearing only a cloth around his midriff. Amerys was wearing her robes, but given that they were enchanted as well, she was probably the most well-armored out of anyone in the group excepting Gazi.

Now the man shifted again, only without the audible *creak* that accompanied Flos' movements. The King absently felt at the offending part of his armor as his steward explained the rest of tomorrow's strategy to the others.

"While Takhatres and Amerys deal with the mages, Gazi will attack the rear and whatever spots she deems most important."

"As normal."

Drevish snorted. Orthenon paused and stared at the old man's back. Drevish raised a hand in half-hearted apology and the steward continued.

"Finally, my lord and I will lead the vanguard straight into the right flank. We'll leave the rest of our mages and archers in the back—Takhatres will pull back and protect them after he is done with the mages."

"A fine plan."

Flos smiled as he looked out over the battlefield. There was so much grass there. He could see it even in the darkness that now enveloped the land. But soon that grass would be muddy and trampled, stained with blood. That bothered him as much as the lives that would be lost.

"Are you expecting any surprises?"

Gazi turned and looked at Orthenon. The man shook his head.

"None. But if there are...Mars is on the way. She should arrive at midday—sooner if she's marching as fast as I think."

“We could wait for her and smash this army between both ours and hers.”

Amerys smiled. Takhatres and Orthenon looked disapproving. Flos shook his head as he finished his cup.

“We could. But that would not be honorable, Amerys.”

“Oh very well. In that case, I shall do my best to kill as many soldiers tomorrow as I can—honorably, of course.”

Her remark elicited a glare from the two warriors, but Gazi smirked. Flos just shook his head as he stared down at the burning fires of the camp below. All fell silent. After a few more minutes, Drevish spoke.

“On another note, I have located quite a fine spot to build a defensive tower. When the battle’s over I’ll see about laying down the foundations.”

“A tower to go along with your new wall?”

Flos chuckled. His voice was lower, and he felt calm. He thought he might sleep here if the others wouldn’t have objected. He was at peace in this moment, surrounded by five of the people who had become his sworn companions. His friends.

“Why not? You can spare a few [Archers] for it, surely. Do not quibble over my designs if you won’t do the same for your other vassals.”

Drevish half-turned and scowled at his King. That was an offense that Orthenon and Takhatres wouldn’t have ever dreamed of, but Flos was used to it.

In a way, the [Architect]’s presence had not been necessary to the night’s meeting. He would not participate in the battle. Rather, Flos suspected he would sleep right through it, if he didn’t end up sketching plans for a new fortress in his tent.

He didn’t need to be here. But in another sense, he absolutely had to be with them. He knew it, and the others knew it. And it was Amerys who gave voice to that feeling. She smiled as she leaned against her King.

“This is the first time in what, two years? The first time we’ve had four of the Seven together, not counting Orthenon and my liege.”

“True. And tomorrow it will be five.”

Takhatres stared pensively out into the darkness. He shifted from one leg to the other; he had trouble sitting for long periods.

“It is a shame the others couldn’t be here. But then, it is also pointless to have us all together. We are too strong for any one army in this region.”

Flos turned to look down at Gazi. She was shorter than he was, and she stared out at the enemy’s camp, her other eyes scanning the hilltop. Always watchful, wary of any threat to her [King].

The others sitting around Flos made similar noises of agreement and regret. But it was Flos who felt something stir in his chest. He sighed as he placed his cup on the ground, empty.

“It is true there is little merit to keeping us together for strategy’s sake. But pointless? No. There is meaning to this.”

His words silenced the others. They stood or sat with him, staring out into the darkness. All was silent. All was calm. And as Flos sat, looking at his companions, he smiled. He was thousands of miles from the place he had grown up, in a distant land, about to fight another battle against a nation whose name had already been forgotten.

But here, in this moment, he was home.

Flos reached out, looking for his cup. He knew what came next. He would lift his empty cup and Orthenon would check whether there was any wine to fill it. He knew Gazi would smile as she wickedly told him he had drunk the last of it. In a moment Amerys would offer to fly down and steal some from the soldiers. Drevish would encourage her and Takhatres would lose patience and run down and get some in a flash, and Flos would be laughing too hard to tell any of them he hadn’t wanted a drink, merely to toast in spirit.

All that would happen in moments, Flos knew. It would be a perfect interlude before they slept, before the battle. So he reached for his cup—

And then he woke up.

The man known to the world as Flos, the King of Destruction, woke up in his bed. It was familiar to him. It had been the place he had slept for the last twenty years. Though the mattress had been changed, the frame of the bed, deep, expensive wood, and the large room had not. Flos sat up as the dawn's light fell on him. It was that which had woken him from his sleep. Even after two decades, he rose with the dawn.

But he did not get out of bed. Flos stared at the wall of his bedroom, not staring at anything in the waking world, but chasing that dream, that vision of the past.

It was no use. It slipped away from him, fading with each moment. Soon, it was just a hazy recollection, not the reality he had experienced. For a second Flos could still taste the cheap wine on his tongue, feel the stone beneath his legs and the ill-fitting armor digging into his shoulder—

And then it was gone. It was all gone. Flos looked around the room and felt years settle on him like stones. He remembered, and saw the block of ice sitting on the table across from him. Staring at him.

Flos buried his head in his hands. The man wept. He let grief overtake him for a minute, and then six. But then he stood, and dressed himself. He threw open the curtains and let the sun bathe him for a second. He stared down at a kingdom below, a ruined city, neglected. But burning now, already moving as the people below woke. They were not dead. The spark lived in them. The man took a deep breath of the air.

And when he threw open the doors to his room and strode out, he was a King.

Trey Atwood was eating breakfast when Flos woke up. He knew that because he could feel it. That was the thing about living in the proximity of

Flos, the legendary King of Destruction. You could tell when he was nearby, and you could tell when he woke up.

It was like a little shock to the spine. It made Trey's heart jump, and he looked up from his plate of crunchy bacon bits. He'd been quite enjoying his meal—proper rashers, not the greasy bacon he'd been forced to eat when he'd stayed at that international hotel one time. This was thick, chewy meat which he loved, and he'd specifically requested the crunchy fried bits.

"I think he woke up, Teres."

"Of course he did."

Sitting next to him at one of the dining tables in the banquet hall, his twin sister Teresa, who preferred to be called Teres, turned and frowned at Trey. He knew he didn't need to say it. She'd felt the same thing.

"I reckon he's going to be here in five minutes, what do you think?"

"Two. And you'd better finish eating your veg. You know he's going to be eating while he walks again."

Teres reached over and stole half of Trey's remaining bits of crispy bacon. He groaned, and groaned harder when she turned his plate so he could stare at the orange tubes on them. Even in another world, he still didn't like the vegetables.

"Aw. Teresa..."

She elbowed him. He knew she hated it when he called her by her full name. Reluctantly, Trey began crunching down on the orange vegetables, called yellats, grumbling about how they'd gone cold.

In truth, these vegetables were a lot more fun to eat than asparagus, spinach, or most of the other greens Trey had suffered through back home. They were spicy, and they *crunched* delightfully loud between the teeth. They were a treat when fried hot with oil, but since Trey always left them for last, he always ate them cold.

Always, meaning for the last month, really. It was an odd thought, but Trey had hardly been in this world, this new world filled with levels and

classes and Skills, for more than a few weeks. It was incredible to him, but there it was.

He was in another world. And not only that, he was a guest in the palace of a king. Not just any king, too. The King of Destruction, one of the most famous people in this world, a man whose name was known in every part of it for his legendary kingdom's rise and sudden collapse. The man who had been slumbering, asleep in his palace for twenty years.

Until Trey and Teres had accidentally fallen into his throne room and woken him up. That moment would be forever engraved in Trey's memory. He and his sister had stepped off the Tube, the subway traincar's ledge, expecting to walk out onto the platform and head back home. Instead, the ground had disappeared beneath them.

They'd fallen, landing in a magnificent, grand, empty room where a man sat in a small chair. He'd looked up and seen them. And Trey had picked himself up, heart pounding, and stared into two empty eyes, a tired face. He had looked at a man who looked worn down by the years, hunched, alone.

That was how they met Flos, the King of Destruction. After that, men with swords had rushed in, and Orthenon had nearly run Trey through before Flos had stopped them. And then, well, they'd told them everything.

One month later, here they were. Flos was awake, which was pretty important, and Trey was used to eating his food on a wood platter with a knife, rather than on proper plates. It wasn't exactly a series of events that made sense to Trey, but he had eventually come to terms with it. Except for one bit, actually.

"It ought to have been a train station."

Teres looked up. She was chewing down the last of her bacon, and she stared pointedly at the remaining orange tubes, and Trey glumly speared one.

His twin didn't need to ask what Trey meant. She just had to think for a few seconds as she chewed. While both she and Trey weren't identical

twins on a genetic level, they were close enough that they could usually understand what the other one was thinking.

After a second, Teres understood what Trey meant. She scowled at him.

“Well, it wasn’t. And the Tube’s close enough, so stop complaining!”

“I’m just saying, if it *was* a train station it would make sense.”

“You’re not Harry Potter. You’re not good enough to be Ron Weasley. You don’t have a wand and you can’t do magic. What’s wrong with a subway?”

“I dunno. It’s just...weird. And I *could* have a wand. They exist in this world.”

Teres rolled her eyes, but Trey refused to concede the point. They were alike, the two of them, but differed on some fundamental issues. For instance, Trey firmly believed a train station platform would have been cooler and more traditional. Teres thought he was an idiot for worrying about it at all.

“What do you think he’ll do today?”

“Dunno. Fix more walls? Look at maps? We’ll have to wait and see, won’t we?”

That was true. Trey glumly gulped down the last of his food and pushed his platter away. Teres folded her arms as she stared down at her plate. They would have to see. And they would see. Because they had a special role in this world, now.

They were servants to Flos. Servants to the King.

They didn’t have the class, actually. Orthenon had told them not to think of it like that. Trey and Teres were more like aides, although they would eventually be expected to fulfill the roles of bodyguards and assistants as well. As such, they were required to follow Flos around, mostly watching as he attended to the needs of his kingdom.

And there were a lot of them. And Trey understood that things like finding food for the hungry people, or making sure the walls were all intact

in case an army showed up were essential—as was studying maps of the world and sending messages to allies and so on and so forth.

But he was confused, because he wasn't sure why they were here. Here, in this faded kingdom, when he expected to be out, marching in an army. For the kingdom was at war. They were at war, and the knowledge of it hummed in Trey's blood at times. And yet here they were, growing accustomed to a life in this palace. Yet they were at war.

A contradiction. They were at war, but they weren't *going* to war. Not yet, at least.

A second puzzle. Trey slumped over at the table, thinking. Remembering. He knew why they were at war. He had been there the day the Emperor of Sands had sent a gift to Flos, knowing he had awakened. But it hadn't been a gift. The food Trey had just eaten lurched unpleasantly in his stomach. No, not a gift.

He remembered the moment after Flos had pulled out the head from the box the Courier had delivered. It had been—Trey's gut lurched—it had been the head of a man called Drevish. Apparently he was...had been...one of the King's Seven, a group of legendary, high-level people who served Flos.

And he had been killed by the Emperor of Sands. His head had been sent to Flos, and the King had declared war. Trey remembered that moment as well.

Flos had declared war. He had drawn his sword and raced through the halls. His voice had been like *thunder*, and he had shouted that he would not rest until the Emperor of Sands was dead.

Orthenon, Mars, Takhatres, they had all followed Flos, caught up in his fury. Only Gazi had remained, and Trey remembered what she had said to them.

“To victory, children. Victory, and the glory of our King.”

That had sent a chill down his spine. Trey and Teres had stood fixed in place, Flos' voice still ringing through the castle. They'd run out of the room moments later, mainly because the incredibly scary Lady Gazi had

made them. They'd followed Flos and the others by the sound of his shouting voice.

He had strode down the hallways, shouting for his sword, his warhorse, his armies. Trey had seen Flos throw open the doors to the palace—

And stop. He had stopped there, as people ran out of every hallway, holding weapons, shouting, asking what was going on. But their [King] had no answer. And then he'd turned, and walked back towards his throne room.

Not to go back on his word. No, Takhatres had left that very night, promising to strike the first blow against the Emperor of Sands with his tribe. And every day since, Trey and Teres had followed Flos about, witnessing preparations being made. Orthenon, the King's Steward, had begun the immense task of preparing a kingdom that was on the verge of extinction for war against a huge empire.

There was everything to do, and not enough time to do it. People had been starving. They needed to be fed. The walls needed to be manned, and an actual army built out of the people. So Trey understood the need to wait, to take precautions. He just didn't expect *Flos* of all people to wait.

And Teres agreed with him. She thought something had happened too. And in fact, Trey was sure that the others, Orthenon, Mars, and Gazi knew that something was keeping Flos from marching as well. But no one had said anything. Perhaps they could—

“Trey.”

Trey looked up. He had felt it at the same time Teres spoke.

Flos had entered the room. The King was awake and he was here.

The banquet hall wasn't full, but it was hardly empty. Trey sat up in his seat and saw the other diners, servants and guards mainly, turn their heads towards the door.

A King stood in the doorway. He wore no crown, and he didn't carry a scepter. The sword at his belt looked plain, and Trey knew it was normal steel. But he was nonetheless, unmistakably, a King.

And you could feel his presence in the air. Trey stood up. Most of the people in the room did as Flos strode towards them. Men and women were already flocking towards him, one carrying a platter with food, another a drink.

“Good morning to you all.”

Flos’ voice was deep and commanding, like a King’s voice should be. Where it differed from Trey’s image of a King was how...normal it sounded. Flos seldom spoke like a posh aristocrat—Trey had never heard him say ‘thee’ or ‘thou’ and he didn’t tend to make grand speeches either. Still, he made Trey’s heart race the instant his eyes fell on the young man.

It was rather like standing next to a power pylon, or so Trey imagined. When Flos was in the room, it was as if your body was filled with a crackling energy. It was impossible to simply lounge about or ignore him. If you were looking at something on the opposite side of the room, your eyes would eventually wander over to him.

“Trey, Teres. Have you eaten?”

If the first words Flos had spoken were for his subjects, it was notable that the second words from his mouth were for the twins. Trey and Teres automatically bowed as one. Teres was wearing trousers, and so curtsying would only make Flos laugh.

“We have, your majesty.”

“Good. Then I shall eat as we walk. I have risen late, but I intend to do as much as possible before resting. With me.”

That was all he needed to say. Trey’s legs started moving. He walked on Flos’ left, with Teres next to him. Flos accepted the steaming food from the platter with a word of thanks for the beaming woman who had served it to him, and took the mug with his other hand.

“My thanks to you all.”

That was all he said to the men and women gathered there. That, and a nod. But it seemed that was all they needed. The people bowed or called out

greetings, and then Flos had left the banquet hall and was striding down the hallways of his palace, the twins hurrying to keep up.

That was how it happened. Every day. Somehow, it never occurred to Trey or Teres to object. Flos beckoned, or just walked and they followed. Some days Trey felt like a bit of metal following a magnet.

“Is there anything you have to tell me?”

That was usually the second question Flos asked them each day. He was always curious whether Trey or Teres had remembered some tidbit from their world, or if they had found something objectionable or startling in his absence. Trey had gotten used to the question by now and no longer wracked his brain for a response. Honesty was best with Flos. Actually, it was harder to lie to him than simply tell the truth.

“No, your majesty.”

“And you, Teres?”

“No, sire.”

“Well then, let us find my vassals, if they do not find me first.”

Flos laughed and took a bite from the sandwich in his hand. It wasn't *quite* a sandwich, actually. It was more of a collection of bacon adorned with two pieces of dark rye bread added to make holding it more convenient. It didn't have any brown sauce, which both Trey and Teres considered a capital crime. But Flos seemed happy enough to eat it.

The bacon roll was still steaming, and though Trey had eaten, his stomach rumbled a bit as Flos chewed his meal, making comforted sounds and sipping from his mug.

He was done with his food in less than thirty seconds, despite the bacon sandwich being big enough to have filled Trey's stomach and half of Teres'. He drained the mug and handed it to a man who was waiting for that very moment. The servant hurried away with it as Flos grinned at the twins.

“Ah, there is nothing better to start the morning with. Eating food while walking. What a wonderful invention. And convenient! I have eaten on the march before, but this—I enjoy this. What did you call it?”

“A bacon roll. Uh, sire.”

There was something criminal about feeding bacon rolls to a King, Trey felt. Though it was a traditional food, it was just—odd. But Flos had insisted on trying it the moment he’d heard about fast food and walking while you ate. He’d enjoyed it so much that bacon rolls and other walk-as-you-eat foods had become a permanent part of the castle’s served foods.

Flos dusted crumbs from his clothing and turned his head. Trey turned to look too, and saw a man he had grown to know quite well walking quickly down the hall towards him.

The tall man wearing dark clothing was named Orthenon. He was Flos’ steward, which meant he was the second most powerful man in the kingdom. He was tall, gaunt, and he was very graceful. Trey felt Teres miss a step next to him. She had a crush on Orthenon, Trey knew. He just admired the man; there was something about him that spoke of flawless competence to Trey.

“Orthenon. Greetings. Have you broken your fast? I have had another one of those bacon rolls. You should have one too.”

Flos greeted Orthenon, and the man fell into step next to his King without missing a beat.

“I have eaten, my lord. And those sandwiches are not to my taste.”

“A pity. Ah, there you two are!”

Two other people were striding down the hallway towards Flos. On opposite sides of the hallway. Servants were forced to funnel down the middle; they certainly weren’t about to get in the way of the woman wearing brown armor, a two-handed sword strapped to her back, or the other woman, a sword and shield at her side.

“Gazi. Mars.”

Flos called out and the two bowed to him as they took places behind their King. Trey shifted as he saw Mars smile at him and one of Gazi’s four eyes turn to stare at him and Teres.

He didn't know what to make of these two. One of them, Gazi, wasn't human. She was obviously not Human. Not that Trey minded non-Humans that much—he had liked Takhatres a lot. But Gazi...no.

If there was anything to keep your back straight, it was having Gazi standing behind you. She made no sound as she walked behind Trey and Teres, although she was wearing her brown scale armor, but they knew she was there.

She was distracting, even with Flos nearby. Where Gazi was unnatural because of her five eyes, her orange-brown skin, four fingers, and disconcerting way of looking through you, Mars was distracting because of how perfect she was.

She had flawless skin, pale as a moonbeam, and red curling locks that ran down her shoulders. She also had huge breasts. Trey tried to avoid looking at those, but they were...

Significant. Mars also moved like a dancer, and as she walked by Flos, her melodic voice did complicated things to Trey's insides.

"Have you slept well, my King?"

"Blissfully, Mars. It was a shame to wake. But I have slept long enough. Tell me, what news is there?"

The three servants of Flos took turns speaking as Trey and Teres walked silently beside Flos, listening, watching servants get out of the way and people turn to stare at their King.

It was like this every day. That didn't make it any less incredible to Trey, though. The instant Flos woke up, he was surrounded by people. Yet he dealt with them all as if he were completely used to being at the center of the world. That was what it was like being a [King], Trey supposed.

"Work on the eastern wall is going well. We're fixing all the temporary gaps one at a time. It could be going faster, but we don't have enough skilled [Builders] and [Craftsmen], let alone [Stonemasons]."

"How long until we can call all the walls secure?"

“Four days and we could fight off an army of three times our numbers with enough arrows and mages.”

“Good. Orthenon, what news?”

The gaunt man nodded.

“I have located two more of your vassals. Again, they are in mercenary companies, one in Baleros.”

“Far from home.”

Flos sighed. Teres saw Orthenon nod calmly.

“I have had mage [Message] spells sent, but as always, I had to encode my words and send them from another city. It will take time to reach them, if the messages are not intercepted on the way.”

“Why all the cloak and dagger nonsense?”

Mars scowled at Orthenon, her hand on her sword.

“The world will know our lord has awoken soon enough. Why not shout it now and let our allies come to us, rather than play games of secrets like some Terandrian [Lord]?”

“It is prudent. We do not have the forces to resist a combined assault from multiple armies at present. Besides, if word spreads that the King of Destruction has awoken, some of our allies will be attacked by enemies. We must alert them as quickly and as covertly as possible.”

Orthenon turned to look at Mars, unruffled by her ire. The woman shrugged. She was a [Vanguard], Trey knew. A powerful warrior class, and her nickname was Mars the Illusionist. And...that was all he knew about her, really.

“Fine. But it seems strange to me that the world doesn’t know our lord has awoken already.”

“It would be difficult for most to know. Orthenon has kept a lock on word spreading, and it is hardly knowledge most wish the people to know. Most likely all the powerful leaders of nations know, and perhaps groups

like the mages of Wistram or traders of Roshal have found out. But the world? No.”

Gazi’s voice was soft, but all heads turned to listen to her when she spoke. Flos nodded, looking pensive.

“Word of my return is a weapon in itself. I fear that my vassals and allies will be attacked regardless of the measures Orthenon takes. But I will leave it to him to decide what is best. Now, Gazi. What of Takhatres?”

The half-Gazer smiled lazily as all eyes turned to her again. Trey felt Teres shudder a bit as Gazi’s lips moved up. It was a smile, but as Teres has pointed out to Trey, there was nothing really nice about it. The only time Gazi ever actually looked affectionate was when she looked at her King. And even then, she was scary.

“He sends word that he has reached his tribe, and they have begun crossing the desert. I believe they will begin striking at the holdings of the Emperor of Sands within three days or less.”

“Good.”

Flos looked like he had more to say, but he didn’t say it. Trey saw Mars, Gazi, and Orthenon all glance at their King, and then at each other. He wanted to ask the question in his chest, but he didn’t dare speak. The presence of the people around him was overwhelming.

“Well then, I will visit this wall, and then hear what else ails my people.”

The King nodded to himself as he turned left down a corridor. He looked down towards Trey and Teresa, and they both stiffened.

“Trey, Teres. I believe it would be best if you two learned more about the continent today. Orthenon, please take some time out of your day to teach them. After that...Mars, if you would, find out if either has an aptitude with weapons.”

“At last!”

The armored woman laughed as the twins exchanged a glance. Today was the day? Flos had been hinting—Trey raised his voice because he knew

Teres would never dare to speak.

“Are we—are we going to learn how to fight? Your majesty? What will we be doing?”

“I told you on the day I accepted your service that I would have you follow me into battle and across the seas. If you have the aptitude for arms, it is best you learn from Mars how to fight. If not...I will find another teacher for you.”

Flos nodded to Orthenon. The man stepped away from his King, bowing, and then beckoned to Trey and Teres.

“This way, you two. I will instruct you for an hour and then give you over to Mars.”

“Meet me in the training grounds when you’re done! Don’t fear—I won’t break either of you two!”

Mars laughed loudly as Trey and Teres followed Orthenon away. The tall man glanced down at the two, and slowed a bit; both twins’ legs hurt from trying to keep up with Flos’ long stride.

“I noted your confused faces earlier. Ask me your question.”

Trey gulped, but it was Teres who spoke before him. She was quiet and shy around everyone except Flos and Orthenon. Flos, because it was impossible to stay silent when he asked a question and Orthenon because she liked him.

“Will Lord Takhatres be alright, fighting against the Emperor of Sands by himself?”

Trey nodded. As always, Teres had had the same thought as him. Orthenon sighed.

“A complicated question. Come with me.”

He strode down the hallways, briskly talking to the people who hurried up to him, so that there was a steady stream of people moving towards and away from him. That was the thing. Flos might be King, but Orthenon was the one everyone went to for instructions.

“If you need more wood, check in the storerooms near the dungeons. There might be wood there, but be careful to distinguish between the firewood and usable timber. If there is not enough, return to me. See Master Invac for help lifting—he has bodies to spare for an hour or two. Find five people with tracking skills and locate the source of that nest. Exterminate any rats living within and burn the remains.”

He turned into a room and the twins followed him in. Orthenon stood in front of a large map, adorned with markings for cities and towns, and border lines and the geography of the continent.

“Here we are. Before I answer your questions—a test. Point to me our location, Trey.”

The boy hesitated. He squinted at the map, and pointed. The continent of Chandrar was a rather lumpy rectangle, with elements of oval in his eyes. The kingdom that was the King of Destruction’s home was named Reim, and it was a small dot on the northeast quadrant of the map, closer to the border than it was to the center.

Desert and the dry, faded dust coloring indicating arid land surrounded Reim, as well as the large area around it. That was most of Chandrar, actually. While there were green patches to the southwest and along the coasts, most of Chandrar was one big dry place. With lots of deserts.

The lone bits of color actually came from markings that denoted oases or other bodies of water. They were almost invariably located next to a city, and Reim had its own small flush of green that indicated the deep underground streams from which they drew their water.

Orthenon nodded in approval and Trey felt relieved. It wasn’t that Orthenon was a strict teacher; he was, but it was that he demanded perfect understanding. If you made a mistake, he would go over it again with you in exacting detail, and question you on that very thing the next time you met.

“Very good. We are here. While the Emperor of Sands is—Teresa?”

He also called Teresa by her full name, which she normally hated. But Teres never made a complaint to him. The girl pointed without hesitation to

a large section of the map, ostensibly a collection of nations by their borders, almost directly west of their position.

“Correct. This map is outdated of course—but the nations from here to here are where the Emperor of Sands has expanded his empire in the last eight years.”

Orthenon traced his fingers over a vast stretch of land, from the west to the edge of a massive desert. He pointed that out to the twins.

“The one thing that has stopped his expansion is the desert. Marching an army across the Zeikhal desert is dangerous, and I believe the Emperor of Sands wishes to consolidate his hold over the west before expanding. He may eschew crossing the desert and conquer his way north and south to avoid it.”

Trey nodded as he saw Orthenon trace possible routes that avoided the massive Zeikhal desert. As far as Trey understood the world, it was vast. He had never been good at geography, but Teres told him that the Zeikhal desert was probably twice as large as the Sahara in total. He couldn’t imagine that.

“So Takhatres is crossing that? Isn’t that...bad?”

Trey felt like an idiot for asking the obvious, but he didn’t understand.

“Not to his tribe.”

Orthenon smiled at Trey. Perhaps it had been a good question after all? The man showed Trey where Takhatres had been.

“His tribe is nomadic, and used to crossing the deserts. Moreover, they move quickly. They can skirt the outer regions and make use of oases. They will be fine. But as to your main question—Takhatres believes, as do I, that he can attack the Emperor of Sands without being cornered by his armies.”

“So he’s going to fight a guerilla war.”

The tall man paused. He always seemed a bit surprised when Trey and Teres knew something without him explaining, for all that he knew they were from another world.

“Correct. He will raid villages, destroy cities—and attack any army he believes he can rout with few casualties. He is adept at such maneuvers.”

“But the Emperor will send armies after him, right? He wouldn’t just ignore that.”

“True. But Takhatres’ people, the Garuda, are known for their speed. Flying and hiding, they could easily escape most pursuit. And there is another factor to consider. Takhatres’ tribe is far superior to any one conventional army. With him leading them, they could fight two armies at once. Catching him will be no easy matter and will occupy the Emperor of Sands for a long period of time. And while that is so...”

“We’ll attack?”

It was strange, saying we. But Orthenon nodded as if it were only natural to include them.

“In theory. I have advised my King—and would like you to do the same if he thinks otherwise—of striking nearby nations first. We must recover strength before doing battle with a vast empire.”

“But we are at war, aren’t we? Flos—I mean, King Flos said—”

“Oh yes.”

Orthenon’s voice was quiet as he traced the lands of the Emperor of Sands. He did not look so friendly then.

“We are at war. But we must be prudent and sensible in a war of vengeance. We must gather our strength, and my lord Flos knows this.”

“Is that why he hasn’t left yet?”

Trey blurted the words out before he could think twice about saying them. He’d been wondering—Teres had been wondering that very thing for days now. Ever since Flos had declared it.

The [Steward] paused, and looked at the twins. He seemed conflicted. When he spoke, it was not with his usual surety.

“I—believe so. I do not have to tell you what the Emperor of Sands did was unforgivable. There will be no peace until he and his entire empire is

brought to justice. But as to my King—you are right. I would expect him to ride forth, regardless of the danger. I was prepared to stop him, but he—”

“Why didn’t he go?”

Orthenon had no answer. He looked back at the map.

“Perhaps it is caution that stays his hand. A King must think of his realm, and it is dangerous to go forth without preparation. That is what I believe.”

“The city is being repaired quickly. I should think it would only be a month before everything’s repaired.”

“Yes. A month. Perhaps sooner, if all continues to go well.”

Orthenon nodded in agreement, but he looked troubled as he did. Trey exchanged a glance with Teres, and they had the same thought.

“What will we be doing?”

Orthenon paused.

“You will accompany my King, and assist him as you are able. For now, I believe you will simply follow and observe. Your...presence matters to my lord Flos. Just by being by his side, you fulfill your roles.”

“Is that all?”

Teres stared at the man. Orthenon shook his head.

“Your duties are unclear as of yet. But you must have faith in your [King].”

He stared at the twins. The twins stared back, waiting for more. But that was all there was to it. After a moment Orthenon turned back to the map.

“Enough. I am here to teach you, and so I shall. We have little time left in any case. I taught you of the peoples of Chandrar, did I not? Teres, repeat for me the native inhabitants of this continent and their specialties. Trey, you will point out where they live on the map as she does...”

“Caution? Hah! That is an answer Orthenon would give. But it’s not why my lord hasn’t ridden off already.”

Mars was the second stop for the twins that day. She stood in the dusty training grounds as men and women sparred or trained by themselves. She was wearing a light, elegant tunic, unarmored save for the shield in one hand and sword in the other.

It was a sight to behold Mars the Illusionist. She looked like a champion out of stories, and she was one. But Trey had a hard time staring at her face. Perhaps it was the lack of armor, but he couldn’t help staring at her bare chest.

At her breasts. They were large. Trey stared at them, realized he was staring, and looked at Mars’ face, flushing. But every so often his eyes would slide back down. He couldn’t help it, even when Teres kicked him in the side.

Mars laughed at Trey when she noticed, which made him turn bright red.

“Don’t stare so, Trey. If your eyes aren’t on my sword, you’ll live to regret it. Now, I’m told neither of you have held a sword before, true?”

The two nodded. Trey gingerly eyed the two swords Mars had planted in the ground. They weren’t sharp, at least, he didn’t think so, but they weren’t exactly blunt either.

“Go on, take one each. I’ll test you with axes and other arms, but swords are what I know.”

The two twins gingerly took hold of a sword each. Trey pulled his from the ground with some effort. He was surprised that the sword wasn’t that heavy—he vaguely remembered hearing they were supposed to be hard to lift.

Teres frowned at her blade. She whispered to Trey as she showed him how easy it was for her to lift it.

“I thought swords were really heavy.”

“Heavy? Hah! What good is a heavy sword?”

Mars had heard them. She smiled as she showed them how to grip the swords properly in their hands.

“A sword has to be light and useful. You won’t see many swords heavier than five pounds, not unless you’re fighting a Minotaur or someone who specializes in such things. Like warhammers, I suppose. What, do you two fancy using one of those?”

“No...”

Trey went stiff as Mars went behind him to correct his posture. Teres was glaring at him, but Mars ignored Trey’s awkwardness.

“Alright then, try and strike me.”

“You? But you’re not wearing any armor!”

“And if I was, you’d still not hit me. I have a shield and a sword. And I’m a [Vanguard]—if you two could touch me with a sword, I’d run myself through in an instant. Or ask what level you two are.”

Mars laughed as she beckoned Trey and Teres to strike at her. They did, gingerly, and then with more and more vigor as they realized they really *couldn’t* hit her. Even with Trey on one side and Teres on the other. Even when they timed their attacks at the same time.

Six minutes later, Mars was standing without a scratch on her, and some of the people in the training grounds were laughing at Trey and Teres, who could barely lift their arms. The female warrior had flawlessly blocked or parried or simply dodged every thrust and strike they’d made.

“Not bad. Perhaps you two might be cut out for the [Warrior] class. For now, let’s switch to another weapon. Come on, lift those arms. We can talk when you’re done.”

When they were done and lying on the ground, Mars sat with them, letting the two gulp water as she spoke.

“I don’t know why my King hasn’t ordered me to war. But I think it’s because he’s waiting until he is ready for it.”

“Ready?”

Trey raised his head, trying not to gulp water down and throw up. Again. Mars nodded, looking pensive.

“I haven’t seen him on the training grounds. And my lord Flos was never one to shirk practice. It has been twenty years, and perhaps he wishes to regain his skill before he rides out. A [King] must be strong, to lead his armies.”

“Shouldn’t the King stay at the back? I mean, it’s dangerous, right?”

Mars turned and smiled at Trey.

“Not him. My lord Flos has always lead the charge. When you see him on the battlefield, you will know. Have faith. He will order us to battle soon, and then you’ll see why I’m one of the Seven.”

“But what will we do?”

Trey asked pensively. Mars shrugged.

“Whatever he asks of you. You are sworn to him, as am I. We are companions, in that sense. We are the swords of our lord. When he calls, we must be ready.”

She smiled then, and the twins found they couldn’t ask her anything else. They left the training grounds, unsure of what to make of what they’d been told. Trey and Teres stumbled down the corridors, massaging their sore arms.

“She always seems so loud. And happy.”

Trey confided in Teres as they walked. She turned and glared at him.

“Pervert.”

“What?”

He stared at her. She glared. He slowly flushed.

“I couldn’t help it!”

“So could! You’re disgusting!”

“I’m not!”

“Are too!”

As the two began to argue, they started to lapse into a way of speaking unique to the two of them. Teres and Trey knew each other so well, they could complete each other’s sentences at times. So they didn’t bother to finish theirs when speaking with each other.

“Not *my* fault—”

“Eyes up here! You’re as blatant as—”

“Shut it! You don’t understand—”

“Dog’s bollocks I *don’t*. Just because I don’t have a thing swinging down—”

“Shut up!”

“*You* shut up! Besides...they’re fake.”

“What?”

Trey paused. Teres nodded.

“They’re fake. I’m sure of it.”

“How do you know? Did you touch—”

She glared at him.

“No, but they don’t *move* right.”

“How can you tell—”

“I’m a girl! I know how they’re supposed to move.”

“Oh. Right.”

Trey thought about this as they walked down the corridor. He thought of Mars. Then his mental image focused, as it were.

“They’re really fake?”

“Yep.”

Teres nodded decisively. Trey sighed.

“Aw.”

She rolled her eyes.

“Pillock.”

This might have started another fight, but a low voice interrupted the two.

“Your King awaits you.”

Trey turned, and promptly forgot every other part of the female body. Four eyes were staring at him, and a mouth full of sharp teeth was curved up. It was...reminiscent of a smile.

Gazi the Omniscient, or Lady Pathseeker, or the half-Gazer that terrified the piss out of Trey and Teres, smiled at the twins as they froze up in the hall. She smiled wider.

“He is in his room. Hurry or you will make him wait.”

“We—we will, Lady Gazi. Thank you for telling us.”

“He asked me to.”

Gazi said it simply. She stared at Trey and Teres. They stared back. They had four eyes between them, but since Gazi had four eyes as well it was an equal staring contest. Trey’s gaze was fixed on the center of Gazi’s face.

She had one central eye and four peripheral ones. And virtually no nose. But Trey had never seen her central eye—it was injured. Apparently, a girl from his world had actually poked it out. Trey had no idea who would dare to do that—he wondered what kind of maniac would even try.

“Well?”

Gazi's words made the two twins start walking. But to their extreme dissatisfaction she walked with them.

Neither one of them understood Gazi. She was a hero in the eyes of the people of Reim, and Flos and his vassals treated her with respect. But Trey knew that Orthenon didn't exactly like Gazi, and he was sure that she and Mars didn't get along. Only...he didn't know what Gazi really did.

Orthenon managed things. Mars fought in the army. But Gazi...she was a [Scout], but why would a [Scout] be one of the King's Seven?

"Um, Lady Gazi."

"Yes?"

The half-Gazer turned to look at Trey, still smiling. The saliva dried up in Trey's mouth. Oh yes, there was one more thing. He was quite sure that Gazi didn't like how close he and Teres were to Flos.

But he had to ask. He'd asked Mars and Orthenon, so Trey forced his mouth to work.

"Do you...know why King Flos hasn't ordered us to war yet? I mean, he's not even assembled the army."

Gazi's smile vanished. She stared at him with one of her eyes as the other one fixed on Teres and two more looked ahead and behind her. Trey shuddered as the fourth eye rolled back in its socket. When Gazi spoke, it was calmly.

"I do not know."

"You don't?"

The twins stared at her. Gazi shrugged slightly, the rust-brown scale armor moving smoothly with her shoulders.

"I do not pretend to understand my lord's thoughts. He is a mystery to me, no matter how often I have watched his actions. If you wish to know his thoughts, you must listen to his words, not any others."

"Except he never explains anything."

Teres said that with an uncharacteristic scowl. Trey glanced at her and saw his sister's face was set, and her eyes were flashing with annoyance. He privately understood her feelings; they were being shuffled around again, like every day, really. Flos told them what to do, and they did it, usually without even thinking to ask why or argue. He didn't like it, but Trey felt strongly about voicing his objections in Gazi's presence. Because she might object. Strongly.

"If my lord has no answers for you, perhaps it is because you have never asked. You have a chance now. Here we are."

She halted. Trey realized they'd come to Flos' door. Gazi smiled and turned. Had she just wanted to walk them over? She whispered to them before she left.

"But if you are to ask him...do it now. I have waited a long time for my lord to awaken. And I do not like waiting longer."

She left, and Trey looked into Teres' pale face. He didn't know if that was a threat, a warning, or just her way of encouraging him. But he did know one thing, and that was that he never wanted to meet a full Gazer if they were all like Gazi.

Trey knocked on Flos' door. He heard a booming voice at once.

"Enter."

The twins cautiously opened the door, knowing that the eyes of the other servants in the hall were fixed covetously on their backs. As personal servants to the King, Trey and Teres had some invisible ranking that put them just below the King's Seven in the eyes of the servants. As children, or at least, not full adults, they were also constantly instructed by everyone to be on their best behavior to the King, and their actions were monitored by everyone in the palace.

"So. Have you learned much from Mars and Orthenon?"

Flos turned from his dresser. Trey and Teres jumped. It was she who replied as he stared around Flos' room. He had never been in here. The room was grand and plain. Grand because everything in it was meant for a king. Plain, because there were no paintings on the wall, no decorations—

just a dresser, a closet, a bed and Flos himself. It did not look like the room that had been lived in for twenty years.

“We learned more about other continents, my King. And Mars tested our ability to fight. She says we might make decent warriors if we practice at it.”

“Good. I am not certain that is the best class for the two of you to take, but it is worth considering if you have the aptitude.”

Flos sighed as he regarded the twins. He didn’t look tired, but he did look...less intense than normal. That was unusual, because it was only midday and Trey had known Flos to work late into the night and rise hours later with energy to spare.

“Is everything alright, my...liege?”

The [King] waved a huge hand at Trey.

“When we are not in a public setting you need not address me with titles. Actually...you need not address me so in a public setting either. I have told my Seven and Orthenon the same, but they refuse to listen. But in your world, it is not common to speak to others in such a way, is it?”

“Yeah, but we don’t speak to the Queen.”

Trey pointed that out. Flos smiled.

“But your Queen should have those who speak to her as a person, not as a monarch. It is not always pleasant, to be a [King] at all times.”

He sighed, and turned back to his dresser, picking something up. Trey saw Flos turn back with a brooch in his hands, a bright yellow gem set with violet ones around the gold rim.

“Perhaps that is why I keep the two of you close. Disregarding your knowledge of your world...I crave those who will treat me not as a King, but as something else. What, I do not know. Regardless. Tell me, have you often ventured outside my palace walls?”

“No.”

The two chorused as one. Teres clarified.

“We don’t often go out. But we’ve walked through the city a few times.”

There wasn’t actually much to see. There was lots to do, and so they’d accompanied Flos in rebuilding a house, or seeing to some minor emergency or other. But the people had flocked around him. In the times when he wasn’t there, people were always busy. It was just crumbling buildings and worn down stone as far as Trey was concerned.

“Well, I suppose today will be instructive. You see, Teres, Trey, I desire something of you.”

“Yes, my l—”

Trey bit his tongue. Flos shook his head.

“You see? Already you are so much like the others. But it occurs to me that I am missing something dearly.”

“What’s that?”

“Honesty. Clarity. Someone who will treat me as a friend, a man, a nuisance. Not as a [King]. From you two, I ask it; and I will have it from my people today, one way or the other. I have had such relationships few times before. But it was that honesty I needed. Isn’t that right, old friend?”

Trey had no idea who Flos was talking to. But then the [King] moved and Teres screamed.

There was a head sitting on Flos’ dresser. A head, encased in ice. It was one Trey recognized. His stomach threatened to empty itself as he stared into the bitter expression of the Architect, one of the King’s Seven.

Drevish.

Teres’ scream hadn’t gone unheard. Almost faster than thought, there was someone pounding on Flos’ door.

“My King?”

“All is well.”

Flos stepped towards the door and opened it. Trey heard him reassuring whomever was outside in the background. His eyes were fixed on the block of ice. He kept staring until someone blocked it from view. Flos.

“I did not mean to startle you. I apologize. I had forgotten such sights were not common in your world.”

He spoke gently to Trey and Teres, with a hint of chagrin in his voice. The two stared at him. Teres lifted a shaking finger.

“Why—why do you have—”

“Why didn’t it melt?”

That was Trey’s question. Flos turned and stared at Drevish’s head.

“It was a simple preservation spell for the ice. As to the head...I kept it as a reminder. Of my fallen companion. Of the man I knew. Of my failure. And as a promise.”

“Promise?”

Trey’s voice was faint. Flos turned and nodded.

“I promised Drevish to build a city like none the world had ever seen. In my kingdom. I told him that it would be his plans by which every brick was laid and every house built. That was my vow to him. And I have not kept it. He did not live to see it, but perhaps...”

“You’re going to show it? To his head?”

Teres’ voice was a horrified whisper. Flos nodded gravely. It made a terrible kind of sense to Trey, but his sister was pale and swaying.

“It is all I can offer him. When I show him my kingdom, then perhaps my conscience—”

“No.”

Trey felt a shock. But the word didn’t come from him. It came from Teres. She was staring at the block of ice with Drevish’s head. Flos was surprised too. He stared at Teres.

“What do you mean?”

“No. You can’t let him stay like this. You have to bury him.”

Both Trey and Flos stared at her. There were tears in Teres’ eyes. She looked at Flos, angrily.

“You can’t keep his head like this. Not frozen. Not—you can’t do it. You have to bury his head.”

The [King] froze. Trey froze. He had never heard Teres use that tone in Flos’ palace. He had never heard anyone use that tone with Flos, either. The King’s head bowed. He turned and stared down at the block of ice. His voice was low as he replied.

“He is my vassal. I owe him this.”

“It’s *wrong*.”

Trey looked at Teres. She stood with her fists clenched, staring at the [King]’s back. Trey reached out—to stop her?—but she knocked his hand away.

“It may seem odd to one from another world like you, but it is how I honor my sworn companion. Drevish would understand—”

“No. I know it’s wrong. Trey knows it’s wrong. Anyone would know that! Ask Orthenon, ask Mars or Gazi—”

Teres voice was pleading. She was trying to make Flos understand, but the [King]’s head didn’t move.

“Don’t keep him in this room. Don’t make him stay *here*. Let him sleep!”

She raised her voice and nearly shouted that last bit. Trey was petrified. As Flos’ back turned, he saw an expression he had only seen once before on the [King]’s face.

Anger.

“This is not a matter on which I will change my mind. I failed Drevish. This is his last memory. Here!”

Flos gestured at the head angrily.

“I will not forsake him again. I abandoned him once, and he paid with his life for it. I will not bury his memory and turn away from it as I have so much before. This conversation is over. You two—leave. Seek out Orthenon until I call for you again.”

He made to walk towards his door. But Teres barred his path.

“You can’t do it. You have to let him go. He deserves better than this!”

Trey’s breath was gone. He gaped at his sister. Flos’ brows shot together.

“No. Move out of my way.”

“I won’t.”

Teres was shaking. She pointed at the block of ice.

“You’re keeping him—just like he was when he died! Bury him! It’s disrespectful. And he deserves rest!”

Rest. That word rang true to Trey. He stared at Drevish’s head. It was preserved, so that he could be by his king’s side even in death. Whether he liked it or not. Just like...Trey. And Teres.

Flos’ voice was very quiet.

“Do not talk to me about disrespect. I was not the one who killed him. I was not the one who froze him.”

“But you’re the one who’s keeping him this way.”

Flos’ head turned and Trey realized he was the one who spoke. The [King] stared at the two twins.

“Begone from my sight.”

It was a command. Trey’s legs moved him towards the door. But Teres stayed where she was. She clenched her fists. She was shaking with emotion. There were tears in her eyes.

And there was something in Trey's heart too. Something that made him stop, despite the urge to listen to the [King]. His King? Yes. No! A King, but not one Trey had ever sworn allegiance to. A King, but one who had made Trey and Teres his servants against their will. A King, yes.

But not a god.

Trey looked back over his shoulder, and saw a man. Flos towered over Teres, but he was a man. Not just a [King]. And she stood in his way. Because it was right.

Slowly, Trey turned back. He walked over to Teres, and stood in front of Flos. The man stared down at them, unable to believe his eyes.

"I told you to move."

Again, Trey felt the urge to move, but he didn't. Flos was a [King]. Trey was serving him. He had to—

But he was wrong. And someone had to say it. Trey opened his mouth.

"No. It's wrong."

He stared into two burning eyes. There was fury there, uncontained.

"I gave you an *order*. Are you disobeying your [King]?"

"We're not your subjects! We never asked to be!"

Standing next to him, Teresa screamed at Flos. She gave vent to the feeling the twins had felt this entire time. She pointed at him.

"You're the one who decided everything! Well, we're sick of it! You want us to tell you what we think? We think you're wrong! And you can just live with that!"

She stood next to Trey, shaking with anger. And he remembered, dimly, that it was always Teres who started fights. When the twins got angry, she was the one who popped her lid first. He stared at his twin sister with horrified admiration as she finished shouting at the King of Destruction in his own bedroom.

“No matter what you say, we won’t change our minds, you—you bloody *twit!*”

Trey heard ringing in his ears. Teres’ voice echoed through Flos’ chambers, and then there was silence. Dead silence. Trey stared up at the King of Destruction and saw him staring down.

This was where he died. Trey waited for wrath and fury, but heard nothing. He chanced another peek up, and saw something strange.

Flos’ face had changed. There was no anger there any longer, but rather another emotion. It looked like amusement, but there was something else there. Trey had seen Flos laugh many times before, but this was different.

It was amusement and joy. And nostalgia. It was rueful, melancholic. And it was there for an instant, before Flos turned away.

“Oh Drevish, would that you could have been here. Would you have laughed, or told me I was a fool?”

He walked back, away from the twins. Slowly, Flos bent and picked up the block of ice. It did not melt in his hands as he stared down at the man’s head. His friend’s head. When he turned back to the twins, there were tears in his eyes.

A King wept. Unabashedly, his eyes overflowed as he held his friend and stared into his eyes.

“You are right.”

He said that to Teres, and then to Trey.

“You are right. I—I have asked so much of my vassal, my companion over the long years. So much, and yet in death I ask more. To wait for so long...it would be far kinder to let him rest. It was my selfishness that demanded he watch over me even now.”

He turned away from the two. Flos stared down at the block of ice and then bent. He kissed the ice over Drevish’s brow.

“Sleep, old friend. I am sorry. It has been far too long since you treated me like a fool. Somehow, I had forgotten what it felt like to be one. But

these two can speak the truth to me in your absence. So rest.”

He turned and placed the head back on the dresser, only this time faced away from the room. Teres opened her mouth, but Flos turned and forestalled her.

“I will bury him later. Tonight, in private. Now is not the time.”

Slowly, the girl closed her mouth. Flos looked at the two of them, and laughed. It was not the laugh of a [King]. It was a man’s laugh, shaky, and rueful. With a hint of tears.

“I asked you to speak the truth to me, and seconds later demanded you do the opposite. A fool should not do so, let alone a [King]. I apologize to you Teres, and to you, Trey. I am only grateful you could speak the truth to me.”

He bowed his head to them. The twins stood as a [King] and a man bowed to them and neither knew what to say. When Flos had raised his head again, Trey found his voice.

“Your majesty...”

“Flos.”

Teres said that. Trey looked at her, and then at Flos.

“Why haven’t you gone to war? Why are we here?”

Flos looked at them and sighed.

“Because I am hesitating. Because I fear war. Because...perhaps I lack the stomach for it, after all these years.”

They stared at him. The King of Destruction. He smiled at them, looking haggard, weighed down by something they couldn’t name. He raised his hand, and touched the sparkling brooch.

“Perhaps you do not understand. I was never good at explaining such things. Well, I can show you.”

He gestured to the door.

“Follow me, my friends. You two deserve to follow. I am a [King], but I need someone to tell me I am a fool. So come and let me look upon my faded kingdom. At last, let me have the courage to see the cost of my folly.”

He turned and led the twins out the door. And they followed, swept up in his wake as before. But there was something different this time. Trey and Teresa followed Flos, the King of Destruction. But the back they saw belonged to a man.

Just a man. Carrying the weight of a kingdom on his shoulders. And as he walked, Trey wondered. He wondered if Flos had ever had a friend. Perhaps Drevish had been one. Not a vassal, but a friend. Perhaps he had been, perhaps not.

His head sat frozen in his room, a grim reminder of the past. And that would never change. But the ice would melt. The head would vanish from the room, and time would move on. For the King had lost one of his Seven, but gained something else. Two friends, perhaps. Maybe that was what it was.

And he was awake. Awake. The King of Destruction was awake at last. And the world would know what that meant soon enough.

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Trey followed Flos out into the corridor. He walked several steps, then felt someone grab his tunic from behind.

“Wait a second. Don’t follow him.”

“Teres! What are you—”

His sister pulled the startled Trey back into Flos’ room. Then Teres shut the door. Trey stared at her in disbelief.

“Teres! What are you doing?”

“I’m staying here. I’m not haring off this time without knowing what’s going on.”

“Yeah, but he—but—”

Trey stared at the door. Flos had been striding down the corridor. What would happen when he noticed the twins were gone? *Would* he notice they were gone?

But there was no arguing with his sister. Trey knew it just by looking at Teres’ face. Her jaw was set. Teres was still breathing heavily, her cheeks flushed from her earlier outburst.

“I think he’s going to be pretty cross when he realizes we’re gone. We’re supposed to follow him everywhere, remember?”

“Well *I’m* bloody tired of it. Aren’t you?”

“Yeah, but—”

Trey gave up. He agreed with his twin sister. He just wasn’t sure being rude to a King’s face was the best way to go about it.

Resigned, he stared around Flos’ room while Teres crossed her arms and stared at the door. There wasn’t much in the bedroom at all. Except for the head—Trey hurriedly averted his gaze, relieved it was facing the wall—he couldn’t spot anything remotely interesting. Besides the dresser, there was a

wall closet, and a door that led out onto a balcony. But no objects of note. None whatsoever.

Well, there was an empty scabbard propped up against one wall. It was like a footnote, especially since the sword it belonged to was nowhere to be seen. Trey stared at it. That wasn't the same scabbard Flos wore at his side. This one looked fancy, dark crimson and black leather or fabric capped by metal filigree at the tip. The metal looked like gold, and it shone dully the longer Trey stared at it.

He wondered where the sword had got to while he waited. Trey kept staring at the door. Would Flos notice? Or would he send someone to get them? He'd feel like a complete fool if he and Teres ended up staying here for hours.

One minute passed, then two. And then Trey heard footsteps, and Flos thrust open the doors to his room. He stared around, a confused and mildly miffed expression on his face. He caught sight of Trey and Teres and stopped.

First the King looked quizzical, and then his expression shifted to annoyed, and then amused once more. He smiled ruefully and chuckled before thrusting the door wider.

"What is it you two young lions object to this time? I asked you to follow. Honesty is one thing, but I do require a pair of legs so you may follow me about."

"Will you explain what we're doing first?"

Teres glared at Flos. He blinked at her, and then at Trey. The young man had crossed his arms to show solidarity with his sister.

"I am not used to explaining myself."

"Well, we want to know."

It was not witty repartee, but it worked. Flos laughed, and stroked his beard as he regarded the twins. He looked thoughtful, and happy again for some reason.

"Too long. Too long since I have heard dissent. Too long since I remembered—yes I will. I will explain myself. Thank you Teres."

He turned and walked around the twins, towards one of the windows that looked out onto the city. Flos stared down at the streets and people below before turning his head.

“I am Flos. The King of Destruction.”

“We know *tha*—”

Teres’ peeved voice shut off as Flos raised a hand. This time Trey felt his jaws clamp down, though he hadn’t tried to say anything. There was a difference in the way Flos spoke now. He was serious, quiet and thoughtful, as he spoke.

“You have heard of my legend, at least, part of it. Once I ruled over this continent, and sent my armies to the other continents of the world. Some may have said I was poised to create a kingdom that would last a thousand years. But at the moment when the world feared me most, I gave up my throne. I recalled my forces and let my kingdom fall to ruin. I slept. For twenty long years, I slept.”

Trey had heard all of that before. But seeing the King’s face change, he felt like he understood far more. Flos’ face was bitter with regret.

“So I slept. The sleeping King of Destruction, sitting in his rotting kingdom as other nations picked my empire to pieces. My vassals scattered, and only Orthenon stayed by my side. Until I woke. Now my kingdom stirs, and my people rejoice. They say the King of Destruction has awoken, and that is true. However, that does not mean I am yet ready to act as a [King].”

He looked at the twins, something like pain in his eyes. That was a human expression, a mortal one. Not the look of a King. It was intimate, private. Perhaps not even the Seven had seen Flos look like this before.

“Twenty years. I feel as though I am still sleeping some days, Teres, Trey. It is not as if I can begin again so easily, you see? I doubt myself. I fear I have forgotten how to be myself. And yet, I must be myself, and as sure as I have ever been. Because now I am awake, I owe it to my people not to disappoint their faith again. And yet—”

He sighed.

“Earlier I mentioned my fears. I fear what I must do next. You see, I am a specific kind of king. You know it is my class as well as my birthright,

don't you?"

"Yes."

The two twins nodded. Flos smiled unhappily.

"Ah, but do you know the secret of rulers? Not all [Kings] are the same. Those who sit upon thrones become different kinds of rulers. Some pursue peace, and their Skills and classes reflect that. Under their rule crops grow mightily, and their people rest under an aegis of protection. But not my people. No, my kingdom knows only one thing. War. I am a King who pursues war. It is in my nature, and when I act, it will be to lead my people into battle, not replenish the land or rebuild."

A king who specialized in war. Trey released the breath he had held and asked the only question he could think of.

"Are you afraid of war?"

"War? No."

Something shifted in Flos' eyes. He smiled, and his gaze revealed something hungry and eager. And just as quickly it was gone, replaced by another, somber thing.

"I am not afraid of war. I do not fear battle. I long for it. But it is the cost I think of. I cannot shake the cost from my mind."

The cost in bodies? Lives lost? Trey only half understood. Flos nodded back to the window.

"That is why I wish to listen to my people. To understand if they fear what I fear. I do not know. I must confess—that has never been one of my strengths. I can know the will of my people or hear their supplications from their lips, but I often fail to understand the why of it."

"So what are we doing?"

Flos looked surprised as he stared at Teres.

"Listening. We will walk among my subjects and listen, today. It is time for it."

Trey and Teres exchanged a glance.

“But...how can you listen if they know you’re there? Are you going to ask them?”

Flos blinked in surprise, and then smiled.

“No, we shall do it in secret. With this.”

He held up the brooch in his hand. Trey stared at the yellow jewel embedded in the center, nonplussed. Flos stared at his confused audience and sighed again.

“Oh, I had forgotten you would not understand. I should activate this now, perhaps, so as not to surprise you. Very well, observe.”

He touched the brooch and—changed. Before Trey and Teres’ astonished eyes, Flos turned from a King into—an ordinary fellow. Trey didn’t actually witness the change—one second Flos was there, and the next a slightly shorter, less impressive man stood in his place.

He didn’t have reddish gold hair, and his eyes were hazel. His belly had more flab and there were wrinkles in his face and grey mixed in with his dark hair. He didn’t look bad—but no one would ever confuse him with Flos.

Even his voice was different. It wasn’t as resonant, and it had a nasal quality.

“There. You see? A perfect disguise. Now that I think of it, it is better that I used it here, rather than where others might see me.”

“How did you—was that magic?”

Teres rolled her eyes as Trey stared at the brooch. She jabbed her brother in the stomach with an elbow.

“Obviously it’s magic, idiot!”

Flos nodded, showing the twins the brooch. It sparkled in the light from the sun, but didn’t shine or twinkle or do anything else that gave away its nature.

“It was a gift from Mars, years ago. It allows me to assume the shape of an ordinary person, a common man wherever I go. I have made use of it on occasion to learn from my people. I will do so again now.”

“So you’re going out looking like...that?”

“Indeed. And so shall the two of you! Yes, I think that would be best.”

He thrust the brooch at Trey.

“Here. Touch the stone in the center.”

Hesitantly, Trey did so. He heard Teres gasp and looked down at his body. He didn’t see anything wrong. He stared at Teres. Her eyes were wide as she looked him up and down.

“What? What is it?”

“You look different!”

“How? Am I uglier?”

“No—well, you were never a looker but—you’re just different, alright?”

Trey saw what she meant when Teres copied him. Her features altered. She didn’t become uglier or fairer, but her hair and nose and mouth and skin tone changed to make her look more like the people of Flos’ kingdom, rather than a London-born girl from another world. Flos nodded in approval as Trey and Teres stared at each other. Trey had to poke Teres experimentally to make sure she was the same underneath, and Teres exclaimed as she felt at Trey’s features and felt his real face underneath the mask.

“It is a temporary illusion. It will last for several hours if memory serves. We shall mingle with my people while we wear it.”

Flos looked happy at the prospect. Trey and Teres exchanged a glance.

“I suppose that’s alright, isn’t it?”

The strange girl standing next to Trey nodded, looking resigned.

“So we’re just going to wander about?”

“Perhaps. We shall see what occurs.”

Flos rubbed his hands together, looking pleased. He paused as he strode over to the door. Trey had a hard time keeping his eyes off of Flos’ face. There was no longer that strange magnetism around the man, and that was almost as disconcerting as his new features.

“We should avoid going near any of my vassals.”

“Why?”

Flos smiled, and it was another man’s lips which turned upwards.

“They would be able to detect the magic. Orthenon is alert for such tricks and Gazi would be able to see through such illusory magic. Perhaps even without her main eye. As for Mars, she might not notice, but I would prefer not to risk it.”

That seemed weird. Wasn’t Mars the one who’d given Flos the brooch? Flos opened the door and after glancing around for a second or two, quickly strode out. Trey and Teres hurried out into the corridor. Not too many people were about, and they didn’t look twice at Flos, despite him walking out of the King’s own bedroom. They didn’t look twice at Trey and Teres either, which he supposed was part of the illusion.

“Few will notice us, unless they are actively looking.”

Flos spoke out of the corner of his mouth as he walked more slowly down the corridor, the twins following him closely. Trey nodded.

“Um, my K—”

Teres elbowed him. Trey stared at her, and then remembered.

“F-Flos?”

“It has been a while since I heard that name. What is it, Trey?”

Trey gulped. He forgot the last question he was going to ask and blurted out his question about Mars instead.

“Why wouldn’t Lady Mars be able to see us? Doesn’t she know a lot of illusion magic?”

“Her? Hardly.”

The man Flos had become raised his eyebrows, looking amused.

“She is called the Illusionist, but not because she knows any magic of her own. Rather, she possesses many trinkets such as these.”

Trey nodded.

“I remember now. She told me. But why is she called the Illusionist if —”

“Watch it!”

Flos turned his head and quickly stepped out of the way. Trey yanked Teres back as four men carrying heavy sacks of something or other walked past them. One cursed the trio as he went past.

“Keep to the right side, fools! Unless you’re carrying something heavy, keep the corridor clear!”

Startled, Trey looked at Flos. The King looked nonplussed, but as he and the twins looked around they realized that they were getting dirty looks.

It suddenly occurred to Trey that they were walking like they had been before, straight down the center of every corridor as people hurried around them. It was so natural that they hadn’t realized it. But that was how the King and his sworn vassals walked. And once Trey looked, it was obvious they were making a mistake.

The servants, workers, and other people bustling about the palace did not walk down the center or wherever they pleased. Instead, they walked on the right side of the corridor while people going the opposite way walked down the left. The center was reserved for people in a hurry, or carrying things too bulky to go with the usual flow.

“I believe we should walk on this side.”

Flos stepped closer to the right wall, smiling at an older woman who did not smile back.

“Hurry up and move. We ain’t got all day.”

“Sorry!”

Trey and Teres stepped smartly and followed Flos on this new, more proper route. They no longer walked at their own pace; they were now following the person in front. When they slowed, the three had to slow as well or run into someone.

Flos, Trey, and Teres were all unaccustomed to walking that way. But they obediently followed the flow of people on the right side of the corridor, chatting quietly as they did.

“Fascinating. I had no idea there was a system for such things. I suppose Orthenon must have implemented it for convenience’s sake. It is this sort of thing that I wish to experience.”

“Walking?”

“Getting yelled at?”

Trey and Teres stared dubiously at Flos. They didn’t think there was too much special about this, but he seemed privately delighted.

“Yes, and yes. How can I lead my people if I do not walk in their shoes from time to time? It is this experience which—”

He didn’t get to finish his proclamation. An annoyed woman’s voice called out to the three and they saw a grey-haired lady hurrying over to them with a scowl on her face.

“What are you three doing? You’re not part of the interior staff!”

Trey stared anxiously at Flos, but the King smiled.

“We are laborers, Miss. We did not have any work at the moment so we —”

He got no further. A huge scowl replaced the smaller one and the woman snapped at the three.

“If you’re not busy you should be reporting to wherever you were assigned for more work, not wandering about the halls getting in the way!”

Flos bowed his head, looking contrite.

“I am terribly sorry, Miss. I don’t know what I was thinking.”

“Too right! Now if you’re done wasting time—we’ve quite a lot of supplies to be moved. Another [Trader]’s come by and we need all the goods taken up to the storerooms and the kitchens within the hour!”

She pointed down the hall and Trey noticed a stream of people carrying heavy loads coming their way. He expected Flos to refuse, but the man just smiled.

“We would be delighted to help, Miss.”

His comment didn’t impress the woman.

“Too right you will, or I would be having a word with Lord Orthenon directly after this! Get moving you two—I’ll send some others to help unload.”

“We can take care of it ourselves. My two...my niece and nephew here can help me. I’ll carry everything up.”

“Oh, a [Laborer] are you?”

The woman paused to look Flos up and down skeptically. He grinned at her.

“No. Just strong. We’ll have your supplies in a moment.”

Despite herself, the woman smiled. Even with another face, Flos’ grin was slightly contagious.

“If you can do it quick, I’ll have a cold drink waiting for you. For now, bring anything edible to the main kitchens and the rest to the store room next to the library. You know where that is? Then get moving!”

She strode off. Flos nodded at Trey and Teres, and they followed him again, this time heading out of the castle.

“We’re not going to carry stuff, are we?”

Dismayed, Trey stared at Flos. His arms still hurt from practicing with Mars earlier. Flos nodded.

“Of course! I gave her my word I would help unload that cart. A bit of work won’t be wasted while we observe the others.”

“But—aw—but—”

Trey didn’t get any further. In moments he found himself struggling to carry a heavy sack of something on his shoulders. He staggered after Flos as Teres did the same with an equally heavy bag. The King strode back through the castle, carrying five heavy sacks at once. Trey stared, and some of the other people carrying things made startled comments as Flos passed.

“Don’t kill yourself there, Mister!”

“Those bags of flour will wait, no matter how loudly the [Cooks] yell. It’s not worth a broken back!”

Flos laughed and responded jovially as he marched through the halls. He stepped into the huge stone kitchen and after being directed where to put his load, he and the twins set down their cargo and headed back for a second trip.

Trey was massaging his shoulders as he hurried after Flos. The King smiled at him.

“If your shoulders ache after only that, we’ll have to build your muscles, Trey! A set of good armor might not be as heavy, but wearing it for hours on end is far more exhausting.”

“Is that why you can carry all that at once?”

The King laughed as he strode down the corridors, following the right side’s flow of traffic.

“Hah! Well, I must admit that I’ve grown weaker than before. In fact...”

He frowned and his smile vanished.

“That was actually quite unpleasant. Carrying such heavy loads...it is little wonder few choose the [Laborer] class. I am beginning to regret volunteering to carry all of the [Trader]’s goods myself.”

Trey and Teres glared up at Flos. He laughed again.

“Never mind. A promise is a promise. Onwards, you two!”

He strode down the hallway, giving neither Trey or Teres a chance to object or throw something at his head.

An hour later, Trey would have sorely loved to kill Flos for volunteering them to carry an entire wagon-load of goods up several floors to the various store rooms and the kitchen. But any possible threat of violence was impossible; Trey’s arms could barely move and his entire body *hurt*.

He sat at a table in the banquet hall next to Teres. She was slumped over, but sitting next to her, a loud and obnoxiously good-natured Flos was

sharing a drink with some of the other servants taking a break at the same time.

True to her word, the woman in charge of supervising the servants had given Flos, Trey, and Teres a half hour's break to have a drink and a bite to eat. Trey had been too tired to do more than chew the hot, doughy crescents of spiced bread – a popular snack in the region – and sip some water. Teres was the same, but Flos was sipping at his drink of ale and laughing with a group of men and women as they sat and talked among themselves.

“I’ve only ever met a few men capable of carrying that many sacks of grain by themselves. You’d better watch yourself, or you’ll find yourself assigned to ferrying supplies up for good!”

“There are worse fates, I suppose. But I hardly think you all lag behind. I simply feel invigorated today, that’s all.”

Flos smiled as the man sitting across from him, a balding man with scars on his arms, laughed. Someone reached out to slap Flos on the back.

It was a strange thing. Wearing a different face and speaking with a different voice—even without his aura of command, there was something about Flos that drew people to him, made them listen to him. It wasn’t just that he’d done twice the work of anyone else in the same amount of time. It was that he cared. When he spoke, Trey believed without a doubt he was telling the truth from the bottom of his heart.

“In truth, I feel far more tired than I should be. Tell me, has it been so busy every day?”

“Aye. And then some. But we have our breaks and hot food and no one could ask for more. Besides, you know how it feels. We’re alive at last, and a few sore muscles means little for that.”

The man sitting across from Flos sighed. There was a smile on his lips, and a light in his eyes. Trey heard people murmuring agreement around him. A woman who’d been in the kitchens raised her mug.

“Our King has awoken.”

“He is awake.”

The man sitting across from Flos raised his mug to that. He didn’t cheer and no one toasted. But people drank and sat in silence reverentially, as if

those words were a prayer. Trey reached for another piece of fried dough, but Teres had taken it. He looked up at Flos, and saw the man's smile had become shadowed.

"Ah yes. The King. I haven't heard much in the streets. What goes on in the palace?"

"Not much you wouldn't hear about. Gossips always go into the inns at night to talk—"

The others agreed, laughing about how a few tidbits was worth a free drink in any tavern. But then the balding man clicked his fingers.

"What about those two twins, though?"

Trey sat up anxiously.

"What about them?"

The man sitting across from Flos laughed.

"Haven't you seen them, lad? They're scarcely older than you—but they're a different type than you and I. Foreigners, from Terandria perhaps."

"I heard they were from further than that. But I've not caught the name of the nation from which they hail. No one has. Only our King knows where they came from."

Other heads nodded. The bald man grunted, looking less pleased all of a sudden.

"I don't know what purpose those two serve. Aye, they're young, but Lady Mars said she has no clue why our King keeps them close."

"Really?"

Flos stared intently at the man. He drank slowly as Trey and Teres hunched over at the table, feeling guilty.

The bald man nodded. He leaned forwards conspiratorially, but kept his voice loud enough for everyone at the table to hear.

"She says they're completely unskilled with any weapons. And that's true enough. I saw them in the training grounds, flailing about with swords as if they'd never held one before. That brightened my day."

"Hm."

“I’ve no qualms with them being here, but I’ve been told they’re to be treated with the same respect as one of the Seven. Imagine that!”

“Lord Orthenon seems to respect them, and I have no earthly idea what Lady Gazi thinks. Lady Mars seems to share our opinions, but she’s respectful enough. I wonder what merits our King’s trust in them...”

The others around the table began gossiping about Trey and Teres. Trey was relieved that none of them had specific complaints, but he felt wretched. He was relieved when Flos cleared his throat.

“The twins are one thing. But what about the King?”

“What about his Majesty? I saw him walking down the hall just this morning. He met my eyes and I’ll swear to you all, he was the same man he once was. Just as great.”

The balding man spoke proudly and everyone nodded. But Flos shook his head.

“If he is as he was, that means war is coming, isn’t it?”

“And if it is?”

The man stared challengingly at Flos. The King did not respond. The laborer drained his mug, speaking loudly to everyone at once.

“If it comes to it, I’d be the first to grab a sword and follow him into battle. He has but to ask. Once our King raises his banner, we’ll follow him as before.”

“As always.”

The female [Cook] said that, and the people around her nodded. Trey blinked as he saw every face just as resolute as the balding man’s. *If he but asks, we’ll go to war.* He looked at Flos and saw something different written on the man’s face.

Anguish. It was there for a second, and then gone. Flos turned to look at Trey. Then he resumed listening to the people talking in loud, excited voices.

What did it mean? Something had bothered Flos. And it was why he had come here. Trey understood that without needing to be told. But what?

“Why is he upset?”

Teres whispered into Trey’s ear. He shrugged and looked around the room. No one looked upset. Just the mention of war had made other people come over. Some, most were civilians who’d never fought, even before Flos had slept. But a few at the table including the balding man had been soldiers. They spoke proudly of battles past, and of battles to come. There wasn’t a trace of fear or hesitation in their eyes.

So what had Flos seen?

It was a slow realization. It dawned on Trey as he watched Flos mingle and talk with the other servants and laborers, ordinary citizens, craftsmen and soldiers. It was in their wrinkled faces, the way they doted on Trey and Teres, asking where they had come from, where their family was—questions the twins had a hard time answering honestly let alone dishonestly.

It when Trey saw the youngest woman in the room, the young [Cook] in her mid-twenties, that he finally understood. He nudged Teres at once as he watched Flos laugh uproariously at a joke someone had told.

“I get it, Teres.”

“What?”

Trey hesitated. How could he explain? He thought and whispered into Teres’ ear.

“Think about the Great War, Teres. The Lost Generation—you know? Think of it like that. Only the opposite.”

She looked blankly at him, and then her eyes widened. She took in the room, the aged faces. The lack of young ones.

“Oh.”

It wasn’t the faces Trey saw that had bothered Flos. It wasn’t the living. It was those who weren’t there. The children. The young people. There were scarcely any people Trey and Teres’ age, and he had seen...how many children over the month he had been here? So few.

It was a flash of insight. Flos, the King of Destruction would go to war. He would ride off, and his kingdom would rise with him. They would

follow his banner into war again, as they always had.

Only this time, no one would come back. Or rather, there would be no one to come back to. This time, there was no generation of young men and women to fight. It would be the fathers and mothers who took up arms, every living soul. There weren't enough bodies left. This generation would be the last.

This was Flos' kingdom. Dying. They had come to life, but that life was fragile. Tenuous. They were what remained, but if Flos rode to war, there would be nothing left.

Trey looked up and saw Flos looking at him. The King nodded, and turned back to the laughing men and women. When he spoke, it was quiet, but his voice quieted the loudest laughter.

"What a terrible King."

He sat at the table as sound died around him. Trey saw every head within earshot turn. The balding man stared at Flos, joviality gone.

"What was that, fellow?"

"I said, what a terrible King he must be. To ask you all to fight and die again. What sort of King could ask that of his people?"

No one spoke. Trey looked around at the suddenly hostile faces. The balding man pushed away his drink.

"Are you new to Reim, stranger? Or did you never lay eyes on our King before now?"

Flos met his gaze squarely, without passion.

"I have seen him before. As he lay slumbering while his kingdom fell to ruins."

"Then you know nothing."

The bald man stared at Flos, face reddening. He pushed back his chair.

"If you never met our King before, then you've no right to speak of it. He may have slept, but we kept faith with him. We waited, and when he calls, we will go to war and yes, die for him without fear. Because he is our King. Now, I've got to be getting back to work. And you had best leave."

He stood up, staring at Flos. The King stood as well, and Trey and Teres scrambled out of their seats. Everyone was staring at them. But Flos didn't turn to leave. He stared curiously at the balding man, as if he were staring at something he'd never seen before.

"Why would you follow a King who abandoned you? Who left his kingdom to rot? Why would you love such a worthless King?"

The bald man stared at Flos across the table. His face went crimson, and then white with anger. His voice was barely contained.

"Because he is our King. Because we love him. Because we would follow him to the ends of the earth. Because he is worthy of *respect*."

Flos shook his head.

"He is not."

Silence. Trey saw the tendons bulge on the balding man's neck. He saw his hand move in slow motion—and then the man threw a punch at Flos.

It was so quick that Trey missed the blur of movement. He only saw the second part of the punch, as Flos leaned backwards, avoiding the blow.

"*Bastard!*"

The balding man leapt onto the table and started swinging at Flos. The King dodged backwards, letting each punch miss him by inches. But there was only so far he could back up. He blocked one punch towards his chest, took a step back, and ran into Trey. Flos took the second blow to the face which sent him sprawling and a kick to the stomach before people pulled the bald man off of him.

"Get out. Take your uncle with you and don't set foot in the palace again if you want to walk out."

The balding man spat at Flos as Trey and Teres helped him up. The other servants and workers held him back, but no one spoke up in defense of the twins.

"Come on."

Trey and Teres pulled at Flos and he let them pull him out of the hallway. Once they were out, Trey and Teres set a fast walk, hurrying Flos

down the corridor. Only when they were a good minute away did Flos speak.

“Well, that was enlightening.”

The twins stopped and stared at him. Servants behind them cursed and dodged out of the way as Flos rubbed at his cheek. It was already swelling up.

“*What?* What do you mean, it was enlightening?”

“Exactly what I said. I am glad to have spoken to that man. Although I wish you two would have backed up. I needn’t have taken that punch otherwise.”

The mildly reproving tone and glance towards Trey nearly made him lose it altogether.

“That wasn’t *our* fault! You started that fight! Why didn’t you punch back or—or stop him?”

The King stared in confusion at Trey as if *he* were the one not making sense.

“Don’t be ridiculous. What sort of King would attack his own subjects?”

Trey’s mouth worked helplessly as Flos led them on again.

“The...kind that doesn’t want to be hit?”

“Hah! Good point.”

Flos grinned at Trey as he rounded a corner, tapping the gem in the center of the brooch twice. One second he was a wincing, commonplace laborer, the next, he was a King. Trey wouldn’t have noticed the slight swelling around his cheek at first glance. The sheer...Flos-ness of the man overwhelmed details at first glance.

“My King! Good morning to you!”

“Good day to you.”

Flos waved at servants who exclaimed upon seeing the King appear out of the middle of nowhere. Trey saw the corridor full of people behind him do a sudden double-take and stare in amazement at Flos. They called out

greetings too as Flos abandoned the right side of the corridor and strode down the center again. It was better that way; people got out of Flos' way no matter where he walked.

"I can't believe you let him hit you. Why did you call yourself a bad King?"

"Because I am. Because it is true. They may see me as a King worth following, but I will not give myself such laxity. I have failed them. That they would follow me is a mark of the worth of my subjects, not myself."

Trey stared at Teres. She shrugged. Then she frowned at Flos.

"Why didn't you tell them you were the King, then? Then they wouldn't have kicked you. Or thrown beer on your head."

"Was that what it was? I thought it was water. But why would I reveal myself?"

Flos felt absently at his damp shoulders. Trey tried to explain, feeling all the while that he shouldn't have to.

"Well, isn't that what you wanted to do? It's like...it's like all the stories."

"Stories?"

The King halted in the middle of the corridor. He made Trey explain to him what he meant.

"In stories of...King Arthur, I guess, he pretends to be a beggar, or an ordinary knight. He goes around doing good deeds and learning about folks, and then he reveals himself to them afterwards as the King."

"Why would I do that?"

Flos looked blank. Trey opened his mouth and paused.

"Because...because then they'd know it was you?"

The King shook his head, frowning.

"If I were to do so, then that man would have realized he raised his hand against his King. I would not trouble him with that knowledge. And besides, it is best I keep such tricks secret."

"But you got punched."

“Yes, I did. But it was important. And I have a healing potion in my rooms. Follow me.”

Flos refused to continue the conversation until they were in his quarters. There he took a bottle of clear blue liquid from his drawer and let Teres dab a tiny bit of it onto his cheek.

“My stomach will be fine. But a King cannot be seen with a swollen cheek. That much is true.”

“So why did we do all of this?”

Trey complained as he eyed the potion bottle. He was wondering if he could use some on his sore shoulders. Or arms. Or legs. Or if he could take a bath in it. Flos sighed.

“You saw what will come, did you not? Death. Death for my kingdom and my people. It is war I walk towards, and it will take their lives.”

“Isn’t that how war always works?”

“It is. But I had not thought of the cost of it until now. When I was young I did not know why my people followed me, even to their deaths. Now I know, and I am humbler for it. They showed me their feelings—”

He winced as Teres touched his swollen cheek.

“—Quite clearly. And it is good that I know it. Because I must be the King to fulfill such expectations.”

He sat on his bed, head bowed as the healing potion worked its magic and his cheek returned to normal in seconds. At last, Flos raised his head and smiled tiredly at the twins.

“Children, did you see the other part? When I became a King again, did you see it in the eyes of my people?”

“See what?”

Flos smiled bitterly. He stretched out one huge hand and stared at it as he spoke.

“They do not see me. They stare right through me, at something else. An illusion far more complete than any Mars could create. At a dream.”

Teres was the one who hesitantly replied.

“You mean...at the King you used to be? Before you slept?”

“Not even that.”

Flos shook his head.

“They see a King who never existed. Their ideal King, the ruler they made from shattered dreams as I lay slumbering. A King without fault, who will bring them salvation. I am not that King. I never was. I never will be. And yet, that is the King I must be.”

He stood up. He took the bottle from Teres and gently put it back into the drawer of his dresser. When he turned, he stood taller than ever, or so Trey thought. And when he spoke, it was as a King, so that every word hung in the air.

“My subjects dream. It is a King’s duty to turn that dream into reality. I am a King, and I must act like it. I cannot hide behind petty tasks anymore. It is time to be a King in truth.”

He gestured towards the door, and this time the twins walked out with him behind them. Flos explained as they walked through the corridors, every head turning and bowing towards him.

“In truth, Trey, Teres, I have not acted as I should. You have seen me supervising the repairs of a wall, or managing supplies, dealing with the affairs of my kingdom. And while those are true and pressing tasks, they are not mine. I have always left such things up to Orthenon, my [Steward].”

“You did?”

“Of course! He is far more competent than I at such matters. Whenever an issue of logistics popped up I believe I said...what was it now? Ah, yes. I would probably say ‘Orthenon, take care of it’ and leave it to him.”

The twins gaped at him. Flos raised his eyebrows.

“What?”

“You didn’t even say ‘please’?”

“Should I have? I am a King, and he is my [Steward]. My faith in him is complete.”

“Yeah, but—”

Trey shook his head, an activity he had come to associate with Flos. He looked around, frowning, as he realized where they were going.

“Are we headed to the map room?”

“Yes!”

Flos smiled as he threw open the doors to the room where strategy was planned and Orthenon occasionally tutored the twins. He surprised a woman organizing the carefully arranged maps. He nodded to her.

“Will you fetch us a map so I might view it? I would like a...modern map of the surrounding area. Please.”

He looked vaguely pleased with himself for adding ‘please’ at the end. The woman bowed and immediately found him the required map. Flos unrolled it and the twins stared at the inked lines on parchment.

“Hm. This is only a few years old. But I see.”

Flos sighed as he stared down at the countries and nations marked out on the map. Trey and Teres stared. Compared with the map Orthenon had shown them earlier, this map was completely different.

Most of the nations to the west had been swallowed up by a new empire, the one ruled by the Emperor of Sands. Whereas, around Flos’ kingdom of Reim...

The King traced his finger around the tiny, almost ludicrously small plot of land that was his kingdom. His hand moved up, and he went from nation to nation, staring at the tiny names listed there.

There were so many small plots of land around his kingdom that it looked like a spiders’ web. Trey saw Flos’ finger point to a tiny sliver of land to the north, directly next to his capital city.

“I remember these lands. I remember...ruling them. Now each one is ruled by a [Lord], or part of a larger kingdom.”

He turned quickly away from the map. He nodded at the woman and she rolled it back up quickly.

“That was all I needed to see. Come, Trey, Teres. There is something I must do with the two of you.”

Trey didn't get it. But he followed Teres and Flos out the door.

"What are we going to do?"

"I wish to see for myself what Mars saw. I should have sparred with the two of you myself, rather than leave it all to her. If she does not know your worth, then how can she evaluate you properly?"

"Wait, you don't mean—"

Trey balked the instant Flos led them back to the training grounds. He and Teres backed up to the doorway as men and women training with weapons turned and called out exuberantly to their King.

"We're tired. We can barely lift our arms!"

"Good! That means you've been exercising. But I would like to see your lack of skill myself. Ah, Mars."

Flos turned and smiled in greeting as Mars hurried over. She blinked at the sweaty and irate Trey and Teres.

"Are you going to have them train again, my lord? I gave them a workout earlier. They might not have the energy for it a second time."

"Just a few swings. It has been far too long since I wielded a sword in earnest myself."

Flos accepted two training swords and tossed them at Trey and Teres. Both twins failed to catch their swords and had to pick them up laboriously. Trey froze when he saw Flos had unsheathed the sword at his side.

"Why do you have a *real* sword?"

"Don't worry. It's not enchanted."

"That's not—"

Trey bit his tongue as Flos swung the sword through the air. It was *fast* in his hands. He saw Mars staring with what looked like love at her King as he held the sword. Flos beckoned at Trey and Teres as they held their blades uncertainly.

"Come. I won't injure you two. I simply want to see you strike."

Trey couldn't remember how Mars had taught him to hold the sword. Reluctantly, he swung at Flos' left as Teres viciously poked at his stomach.

Flos' sword blurred and he knocked Trey's blade aside as he parried Teres.

"Good! That was quite a determined thrust, Teres. Try again, Trey. Strike with all the force you have! Don't worry about me."

Gritting his teeth, Trey did. He slashed down at Flos and felt like he'd hit a wall when the man blocked. The sword tumbled out of Trey's hand from the impact. He scrambled to pick it up, hearing laughter as he did.

It wasn't fun being laughed at. Trey's ears were red. He raised his arm, ready to try again, only to see Teres try to cut Flos' head off. She looked as annoyed as he felt, but Flos was encouraging her.

"Good! Spirit! You have a good thrust—you might have run me through there. Perhaps Orthenon would be a good teacher for her, don't you think, Mars?"

"If you want to give her over to him, I won't object my lord. But he and I don't see eye to eye on how to fight."

"Mm. True. Well, what about you, Trey? Perhaps we should let you train with Mars or I while Teres learns from Orthenon's style."

Flos turned to Trey, casually blocking Teres as she tried to stab him in the back of his leg. He motioned her back and raised his sword.

"Mars has taught you to strike, but how about blocking? Come, we'll take turns."

He let Trey strike at him, his sword not budging an inch as he blocked. Then he showed Trey how to hold a shield in his other hand. Trey flinched as Flos raised his sword, but the King laughed and gently swung down.

"Brace yourself as I strike. And don't let your shield stray from your body. When you strike, don't expose your arm or I might lop it off. Good! Keep your shield up as you stab—there."

Within minutes he had Trey gingerly keeping the shield in his left hand up as he struck and blocked Flos' gentle taps to his shield. Soon, Flos had begun using more force. Trey felt heavy buffets threatening to knock his shield away. He braced himself, letting his legs cushion the blow as Flos struck downwards.

"I think I'm ready to stop."

“Nonsense, you’re doing splendidly. Come, strike at me.”

Trey saw Flos’ face smiling broadly as he peeked around his shield. He also saw approving looks on the faces of the others watching him, and a smile on Mars’ lips. That gave him the strength to weakly cut at Flos’ side.

“Excellent! Raise your shield—I’ll be striking from the left. Harder this time.”

Despite being ready for the blow, Trey felt his arm compress against his body. He made a wheezing, gasping sound as he stumbled back. The King beamed at him.

“I—think—”

“Trey wants to quit.”

In his heart Trey blessed Teres. She glared at Flos, ignoring the disapproving faces staring at her. Flos eyed Teres and sighed.

“One last blow then, from each of us.”

That sounded fine. Trey managed to tap Flos’ sword. Then he raised his shield. Flos was smiling.

“Very good. You’ve the makings of a good warrior, Trey. Now—*block!*”

He raised his sword high, giving Trey a chance to raise his shield. The young man did, bracing himself. It was just one more strike. But then the sword came down like lightning. Trey froze. It was too f—

The sword struck Trey’s shield. It didn’t cut through the metal, but the impact of it knocked Trey flat.

Trey didn’t feel his knees give way. He slammed back-first into the ground, hearing his back go *crack* in various places. Trey felt as though his entire body was *whumph*. The entire impact ran through him and for a few seconds he just stared at the sky. Then he remembered he wasn’t breathing and tried to gasp for air.

“*Trey!*”

Once hearing had returned he heard Teres’ voice, and felt people crowding around him. Someone opened an eyelid and Trey tried to make

his eyes focus. He heard his sister shouting angrily at someone and a contrite voice that was Flos'.

The wind was knocked out of him and it wasn't coming back. Trey sat up at Teres' insistence, but then lay back down. He felt...floppy. Could you hit someone so hard their bones turned into rubber?

He felt like he should stand up, but he couldn't. Trey felt himself being picked up and was carried somewhere. He must have fallen asleep, because the next thing he realized he was sitting up in the room he and Teres shared, in his bed.

"Trey?"

His sister was standing over him. She had a bottle of yellow liquid in her hands. Trey opened his mouth.

"I don't want to drink that."

"You don't have to. It's a healing potion."

"Oh."

Trey thought about that.

"Can you pour it on me?"

"No. Hold still, I'll rub it onto your back."

"And my arms. They really hurt."

Teres helped Trey partly undress. Trey groaned as he saw the bruised skin underneath his clothing, already turning spectacular colors.

"Ow."

"Hold still. I'll have you right as rain in a moment."

He let Teres rub the yellow stuff into his skin. It stank horribly, but the agony went away every place she touched. Trey whimpered as she got to his back. Teres was scowling.

"Where's the King?"

"I dunno. I shouted at him and then took you to our room."

"Oh."

“I can’t believe he hit you that hard!”

“I can’t either.”

“He could have killed you! I thought you were dead when you didn’t move.”

“I thought I was dead too.”

Teres glared at Trey. Then she slapped his back. He yelped. She poked him hard in the back.

“Don’t be smart.”

“Ow. Okay.”

After a while, she finished with his back and Trey felt well enough to rub the healing potion onto his legs himself. Teres sat with him, applying a bit to her own arms.

“What was it like?”

“What?”

“Being hit? It looked like he squashed you with his sword.”

“That’s right enough.”

Trey had to think as he tried to explain the feeling.

“Remember when Trevor Martin got hit by that car and had to stay in the hospital for two weeks?”

Her eyes went wide.

“That bad?”

Trey felt at his chest and back again.

“Actually, I think I’d rather trade places with him. That *hurt*.”

“Well, he’s not doing it again. He’s mental, that one.”

“I thought he said he was out of practice.”

Trey winced as he handed the mostly empty bottle back to Teres. She rolled her eyes.

“He says he’s not good at holding back.”

“That was him holding back?”

“Yup. That’s another thing he’s not good at, then. If he’s so special that everyone loves him so, what’s he actually good at to begin with?”

Trey thought about that for a moment.

“Hitting people.”

He lay back on his bed, trying to block the horrible healing potion smell from his nose. Teres lay next to him.

“Do you think I can go to sleep, Teres?”

“I think so.”

That sounded like an awfully good idea to Trey, so he closed his eyes. When he opened them again, after what seemed like minutes, it was to hear Teres arguing with someone at the door.

“We don’t care what he wants. If he wants us, he can come and say so himself.”

She slammed the door. Trey closed his eyes, and went back to sleep.

Sometime later, Teres woke him up. Trey got out of bed, still feeling foggy, but hungry. Which was lucky, because he’d apparently slept till dinner time.

Every day, Flos dined in the banquet hall, at the high table with his trusted vassals while the rest of the people in the hall ate at other long tables. Trey and Teres sat at that table with him as well, but they were used to being overlooked.

Not today. This time, when Trey passed through the tables up to the hall he heard people calling out to him and Teres. Most of them just laughed as they asked Trey if he was alright, or if his head was still in one piece. It wasn’t mocking laughter though, and Trey himself could smile at the jokes.

People reached out, and a few of the older men ruffled his hair, or gave him a slap on the arm.

“Well done, lad. You took the King’s blow like a man.”

“Thought you’d nearly died there. But you sat up, so you’ve got some grit to you!”

It was embarrassing, but Trey still enjoyed it. At the high table, the vassals of the King had words for him as well.

“Trey. I trust you are recovered?”

Orthenon nodded to Trey. Gazi smiled at him, but it was Mars who slung an arm around his shoulder, laughing as she called for a drink for the both of them.

“I took a blow like that from our King once. I couldn’t see straight for two days, I’ll swear! If you can remember your name, that’s cause for celebration.”

Flos himself only laughed as he sat with Orthenon on his right and Mars on his left. The twins sat next to Mars, and Trey found himself in the enviable and difficult position of having to stare past her to listen to the conversation. She was distracting, and Teres kept jabbing him in the side when she thought his attention was wandering.

The thing about sitting at the high table was that the conversation topics were never dull. Tonight’s was especially focused, and Trey saw the servants serving food listening just as intently as the people around him.

“We have a few experienced soldiers, but I fear we must count on a mostly green army to begin with. With Takhatres keeping the Emperor of Sands occupied, our main focus must be on raising the level of our conscripted soldiers.”

“And finding an actual army. We can’t make everyone hold a sword or we won’t have anyone to grow crops, cook, and so on. Plus, we don’t have that many swords.”

Mars stabbed at a piece of chicken on her plate as Flos nodded. He turned to Gazi.

“Your thoughts, Gazi?”

She shrugged. Her eye flicked towards Trey and Teres, while her other three remained focused on Flos.

“We have Mars’ arms. We can outfit an elite core of soldiers.”

“Are you suggesting we take on another nation’s army with a few dozen warriors?”

Orthenon stared at Gazi. She bit into a Yellat and swallowed it before responding.

“We must retake our lost lands sooner or later. Once we do, we will have more soldiers to join us.”

“Declaring the King of Destruction has returned so early is not a wise move, Lady Gazi. It is better to wait for those vassals with their own forces to arrive.”

Orthenon stared hard at Gazi, not deterred by the fact that she had four eyes and he had two. Mars sighed gustily.

“You say that Orthenon, but how long must we sit on our hands here?”

“As long as it takes. There is much to do here, unless you had forgotten. The city is in sore need of repairs, and we can best spend this time planting new harvests for next year, training those waiting to be soldiers—”

“Waiting.”

Gazi said it impassively, but Mars nodded in agreement and Orthenon stiffened in his seat. He opened his mouth to reply, and Flos spoke, cutting the argument apart.

“Orthenon. Gazi. Enough.”

His retainers looked at him expectantly. Flos put down his knife and reached for his goblet. He stared into it and then looked around the table. His eyes did not miss Trey or Teres.

“I have heard counsel from all present. I hear Orthenon’s need for caution, just as I understand Mars’ desire to raise my banner once again. Tomorrow morning I will tell you all what I have decided to do.”

He looked around at his companions. All three nodded and sat back. The conversation turned to less intense matters, and Trey resumed staring at Mars covertly. She really was stunning. Were they really fake?

That night, Trey climbed into bed while Teres took the one on the other side of the room. He felt tired, but not sleepy, thanks to the long nap he'd had. Plus, the downside of using the healing potion meant his body was as energetic as ever. It thought it was time to be up and about, no matter how Trey's weary mind tried to convince it otherwise.

Perhaps that was why he was still awake hours later to see the door to their room open slowly. Trey sat up, heart pounding as a faint candle's light entered the room, held by a shadowy figure.

There were no locks on the door, or if there were, Trey and Teres hadn't been given a key. It wasn't generally needed in most parts of the castle and the servants were in and out of the rooms. But all that meant was that the mysterious intruder could be anyone.

Trey's heart beat wildly as he looked at his slumbering sister. He opened his mouth to shout, and the figure brought the candle up to his face.

"Trey. It is I."

Flos stared down at Trey. That didn't make the young man feel any better. He stared at Flos.

"What are you doing here?"

This time he didn't add 'sire', or 'your majesty'. Flos smiled down at Trey.

"I apologize for the late intrusion. But I have business with you. May I sit?"

"Um. Okay?"

Trey felt the bedding shift as Flos sat on his bed. He sat up awkwardly staring at Flos. The King hadn't changed into his night clothes; he was still wearing the sword at his belt. He nodded to Trey.

"I trust you have healed from earlier? I did not have a chance to ask over dinner, but I am told you used the healing potion I had sent."

"I did. Um, thank you for sending it."

“You should not thank me for that. It was my own fault.”

Flos sighed. He looked ashamed as he stared at Trey, the candle only illuminating parts of his face.

“I was a fool. And your sister was right to call me such. I struck you far harder than I should. It is just that I wished to change the gossip about you and your sister. If you had blocked the blow of a King, it would change what was said.”

Trey recalled all the people who’d slapped him on the back and Mars’ words of praise.

“I...think you did that.”

“Yes, but I did not mean to harm you. That was my fault. I apologize, Trey.”

Flos’ head lowered. Trey stared. It took him a few moments to realize Flos was bowing his head. To *him*.

“It’s okay. Really.”

“It is not, but thank you for saying so. Trey, I realize today I have asked much of you. But I ask that you and your sister follow me one last time.”

“Follow you? Where?”

“Outside my city. I have had horses saddled in secret—a tricky matter, even with a [King]’s authority.”

Flos smiled ruefully. Trey stared at him.

“Wait, but where are we going?”

“A village. It is only an hour or so’s ride away.”

“An *hour*—”

Flos clapped a hand over Trey’s mouth before he could shout.

“I know it is an imposition. But I ask it of you.”

Trey wanted to say no, but he couldn’t find the words. Instead, he resorted to a cowardly, if effective tactic.

“Only if Teres says yes.”

Flos nodded, and gingerly Trey went over to wake his sister. He had to shake her several times. She flailed at him until she sat up. She was ready to curse him out until she saw Flos. Her mouth opened as she glared at him.

“I am sorry for waking you, Teres. However—”

“No. *Out.*”

She pointed to the door. Flos bowed his head towards her.

“Teres, I have one last matter I must ask you to witness. It is of vital importance.”

“No! Can’t it wait?”

The King smiled.

“No, it cannot. Because this must be done alone. No one must know where we are going. Not Orthenon, or anyone else.”

The twins stared at Flos. Trey’s first thought was that he was running away. But that didn’t seem to be the case. Teres folded her arms.

“Why do we have to come?”

“Because I trust you two. And because you are reassuring.”

The twins gaped at Flos. He smiled, and rose.

“Follow me.”

And they did. Teres complained and Trey chimed in, but somehow they ended up dressed and in Flos’ room in minutes. There they stared at the King.

“We’re leaving the city, right?”

“Correct. We must do it in secret, without alerting one of the servants. They will have seen us going into my room, but so long as we are not spotted leaving any of the palace’s exits they will not wake Orthenon.”

“How are we getting out, then? Wait—are we going through a secret passageway?”

Trey immediately grew excited, thinking of revolving walls, illusory doors and magical passphrases. But Flos shook his head, looking wistful.

“I asked Drevish to build me a hidden network of tunnels, but he told me that he had better things to do than waste time creating secret walls and doors. He refused to put a single secret tunnel in my entire palace and told me that if I wished to escape my duties, I should find a way to do it myself without relying on cheap tricks.”

“Then how—”

“It’s very simple.”

Flos went over to the balcony. He beckoned Trey and Teres over. Trey walked out into the very cold night air, expecting to see a rope made of bedsheets, or something else like that. He was *not* prepared for Flos to seize hold of him and then toss him over the balcony.

“Aaaaaa—”

Trey’s scream was muffled by a huge hand on his mouth. He felt hands on him, and then an impact, reduced by the arms that held him.

“There we are. It’s lucky you’re not full-grown or I might have shattered a knee trying that.”

Flos remarked casually as he put Trey back on his feet. Trey stared at him, and then up at the balcony above him. It had to be two stories up. He felt dizzy and had to sit.

“Teres. Jump down. I will catch you.”

The King’s voice was low as he called up. Trey heard his sister reply—and thought she was probably making her opinion clear with a gesture as well. Flos repeated his command. Somehow, in between Trey trying not to throw up, he persuaded Teres to jump.

“There we are. It’s not quite as attractive as a secret passage, but I suppose Drevish was correct.”

Flos remarked to the two twins as they tried to follow him on shaky legs. He led them around to a stable where three horses were indeed saddled. Trey and Teres stared at the horses. Trey suddenly recalled what Flos had said and realized there was a huge, wonderful flaw in the King’s plan.

“I don’t know how to ride.”

“Me neither.”

Flos’ eyebrows rose as he tied a lantern to the saddle of his horse, a tall dark beast which snorted down at the twins.

“You don’t? Well, it’s quite simple. I’ll teach you to guide your mounts another time. For now, just hold tight with your knees. I can command three horses as easily as two.”

Ignoring their protests he put Trey on one horse, and Teres on the other. Trey started as the huge thing between his legs began to move. He clutched at the reins unsteadily as he saw Teres doing the same.

Flos sat on his horse as if he’d been born there. He clicked his tongue quietly and all three horses followed him as he led his out of the palace stables. He rode down the streets, heading towards one of the gates. It was open, despite the late hour. Flos waved up at whoever was on top and Trey heard a voice raised in reply.

And then they were out of the city, racing across dry, dusty ground. Trey stared around the dark landscape, where shrubs of tough greenery sprouted up from the arid earth. He had only been out of the city once or twice. Now the air blew in his face—so cold!—and Trey could look up and see a night sky full of stars. Two moons stared down at him, one pale and yellowish like the one back home, but tinged slightly blue, and the other a shade of purple, glowing brilliant in the sky.

After a few minutes, Flos slowed their rapid pace. He turned the horses at a crossroads Trey barely spotted and turned them up another road, making the horses trot quickly. Now they had a chance to shout, the twins did so. In turns.

“Hush. You might wake someone. Or something.”

Flos ignored their complaints as he smiled. He breathed in the night air and extended an arm, indicating the wide, flat land around his city.

“Look at this land, you two. This is Chandrar. My home. Where it is not desert, it looks much like this. Dry. Some would say inhospitable. But there are valleys and places where nature blooms. And the people who live here are the strongest of spirit, the most resilient.”

Trey looked around. All he saw were rocks, hills in the distance, and an unpaved, dirt road underneath. But he held his tongue.

Beside him, Teres was fidgeting on her horse. Trey couldn't see her face in the darkness, but he knew she was glaring at Flos. She turned her head to him.

"Why do we do it, Trey? Why do we keep following him about?"

Trey shrugged.

"I dunno. Maybe it's a Skill? Or maybe it's because it's him, you know?"

"How?"

"It's like..."

Trey searched for words to describe the feeling.

"It's like, you know, even if something bad happens, whenever we follow him, something exciting happens. And it's usually good in the end, right? It's like the grandest circus and movie and video game all put together. You can't help watching him, the King I mean. And you want to be part of it."

"I don't want to be part of *this*."

Teres indicated the horse. Trey heard it snort. He nodded.

"Yeah, but I guess it's like—you know, a package. You have to take the good and the bad."

"So which is this?"

Trey didn't know. He looked ahead at the King, riding without a hint of discomfort on his horse. Trey felt like his bones were being shaken out of his body, but the King of Destruction was at home here. And he was happy.

Flos was smiling, staring down the dark road lit only by his lantern. And there was something about the way he sat in his saddle, staring ahead, that told Trey something was going to happen.

"Trey, Teres, thank you for today."

They looked at him. The King sat high on his horse, staring into the distance. He spoke loud enough for them to hear him over the sound of the

horses' hooves, but only just.

"This day was special for me. I realize it was difficult for the two of you in light of my errors. I made many, and inconvenienced you and others greatly. But that is what made it so precious for this foolish King."

He waved his hand back towards his city, already part of the landscape behind him.

"You have seen my mistakes, borne witness to my failures. I am glad you have seen me as a man, not as a King. I enjoyed today more than I could say, and I will remember it. But now I must be what I am. A King."

So saying, he stared ahead. And in the distance, Trey thought he could see light. Around him, the darkness was complete. The only light came from Flos' lantern and the stars. But there was a pinpoint of something that was not starlight. It was no electric glow, but it was light. And as they rode on, Trey realized there was more than one speck of light.

"Where are we going?"

"A village."

Flos pointed towards it, guiding his horses along the road. Trey expected to reach the village at any minute, but as they rode on and on, he realized their destination was very far away. It was only because the land here was so flat that he saw it from far off.

"We have left my kingdom. In truth, we left it the instant we passed beyond my walls. This land has been claimed by someone else. A [Lord] or some other land owner claims this village, and receives a tithe in exchange for protection."

The King's voice was low as they drew closer. Now Trey could make out the outlines of houses in the distance. And a wall. There was some kind of wooden barrier around the village, obscuring all but the roofs of the houses.

"They did not have a wall when I last came here."

Flos frowned as he spotted the wall. Teres looked at him.

"When did you last come here?"

He didn't reply. Now the village was directly ahead, minutes away. Trey was shifting in his saddle, his thighs and other parts aching, when he heard a shout. He sat bolt upright as he heard it again. It had come from the village, from the wall.

"They have spotted us."

Flos said the words calmly, but Trey's heart was racing. He saw shapes moving in the distance, and heard more shouting. The lights flickered. A door opened in one of the houses, and Trey saw someone block the light for a moment. He realized the village was coming to life.

"You there! Halt!"

When they were fifty meters or so away from the village, Trey heard a voice. He saw someone standing on the wall, dimly illuminated by a torch's light. He had a bow and he was staring right at them.

"We're no easy prey for [Thieves] or [Bandits]! And we don't deal with travelers in the night. Begone!"

"We wish to enter the village. We come in peace."

Flos raised his voice to shout back. The person on the walls made no reply, but after a second Trey heard a whining sound and then a *thunk*. His horse reared and Trey had to hold on for dear life. An arrow had sprouted out of the soil in front of Flos' horse.

"The next one will strike true! Leave us alone!"

"We should go. They'll shoot us!"

Teres hissed at Flos, but the King made no response. He slowly got off of his steed, patting it to soothe it. He grasped hold of the reins on both Trey and Teres' mounts and guided them off the road with his horse. Then he walked back onto the road and faced the village.

"I ask again. Will you let me enter? I bear you no ill will."

Trey thought the person on the walls faltered. He was not alone; he could see other people manning the wall, also armed. But then the voice came back, loud and angry.

"If you are a Runner or a servant of some [Lord], state your business and offer proof of it! We cannot trust your word alone!"

Flos stared at the village. When he replied, it was in a ringing voice.

“I have a right to walk here. This land is mine.”

That silenced the person on the wall. Flos did not wait for a reply. He began walking towards the village, slowly, staring up at the people there.

“Hold your ground! Hold, I said!”

Flos made no reply. He kept walking. Trey saw the person on the wall move, and another arrow landed in the dirt next to Flos’ feet. The King paid no attention. He advanced on the village. This time, he stopped within sight of the wall, and stood there in the darkness, staring up at the figures on the wall.

“Will you not open your gates to your rightful ruler?”

Trey heard a nervous laugh from the wall.

“Rightful ruler? You’ve lost your mind, stranger. This village pays tithe to [Lord] Venith and [Lady] Maresar. But we have no master.”

“Not so.”

Flos’ voice was calm, distant. He spoke softly, growing louder until his voice filled the air.

“Once, I rode through this village. Many years ago. Yet I still remember that day clearly in my mind. I stopped here, and saw no hope, no dreams in the crushed souls of the people. So I planted my banner in the earth and claimed this land as my own. I told you to rise, to follow me and seek a brighter future by my side. Have you forgotten that day, oh villagers of Manimar?”

For a second, there was silence. Then a gasp. Trey saw the torch on the walls move. Someone took it up and brought it closer to Flos.

“It can’t be.”

They drew closer, and then Trey heard the gasp. The torch fell from the wall and landed on the ground. It cast Flos’ face into light.

Someone screamed. Another man shouted, and then there was a cry, not of anguish, but some other emotion. Trey saw the wall erupt into chaos, and then a voice, carrying above it all.

“The King! *It is the King of Destruction!*”

On the heels of that cry there was another.

“He has returned! Our lord, Flos has returned!”

“Open the gates!”

Within moments, Trey saw the gates open and light stream out. They encircled Flos, and he heard voices babbling, people weeping. The King stood in the center of it all, taking people’s hands, turning to touch people on the shoulder or head. He turned then, and stared at Trey and Teres.

They came closer, sliding off of the horses and stumbling towards him. Flos didn’t move as the gates opened wider and more people came stumbling towards him. He said only one thing.

“I have returned.”

He sat in the village’s town hall. It was a simple building, used for anything and everything that needed doing. Right now, it was filled to the brim. People filled every spot available, those closest to the King sitting and looking up at him, the rest standing around the edges, staring in through the open windows, crowding around the outside.

It wasn’t just one village. Trey had seen people racing on horseback or foot, telling other villages or finding farms. And so over the course of the fading night people had come streaming in, come to see the King of Destruction, Flos.

Their King.

He sat in the center of it all, talking quietly. He just talked. He sat on a chair or stood, pausing as each person went to him. And he had a word for them all. Trey and Teres watched as he met an old woman who had seen him as a youth, or a man who had lost a son who’d joined Flos’ army, or an old man who’d fought with Flos on the battlefield.

They all knew him, had had their lives touched by him. And Flos knew them all. He knew every face, remembered people he'd only spoken to two decades ago. He looked at them all, and his eyes were filled with tears.

But he never wept. And as night turned into day and the sky began to lighten, Flos spoke.

"Long ago, I came to this very village. I rode through with an army and told you all to follow me. I told you I would overthrow every nation, every rule of law and every government. I asked you to break all bonds and follow me for a brighter future."

All the voices in the room went silent. Flos looked from face to face.

"Twenty years ago. No—more than that. When I was a boy, I called upon you to be my sword and shield. And you did. You sent your sons and daughters, and you picked up arms to follow me. You marched across nations, through rivers, from one end of the continent to the other."

"And we will again!"

A man stood up. He was trembling.

"Ask it of us, your Majesty! Raise your banner and we will serve again!"

People cheered and shouted in agreement. But Flos raised his hand slightly and they were silent.

"You did once. How many came back from my endless wars? How many lie buried thousands of leagues from home?"

No one could answer that. Flos looked around the room and shook his head.

"So many were lost. Too many. And yet, each man, woman, and child died with that same dream in their eyes, that same fire in their heart. A brighter future. One worth fighting for. For that alone it was worth it."

They nodded at that. Flos paused. His fist clenched.

"But then came the day when I faltered. I lost the will to continue. I stepped off my throne and put down my sword. I disbanded my armies, and left my vassals to scatter to the wind. I let all of you down, you that had journeyed with me so far."

He looked at them, tears in his eyes.

“I failed you.”

Instantly there was a babble of dissenting voices. Flos raised his voice above them all.

“I *failed* you. All of you. I abandoned my duties as King. I slept! For twenty years I slept and you all have suffered my neglect. I am not worthy to call myself your king.”

Again, they shouted in denial. But Flos kept shaking his head. He waited until they were all quiet again.

“And yet, I am your King. That fact will never change.”

He stood, and turned slowly around the room. Men and women stared at him, old warriors and mothers, farmers and shepherds. Widows and children.

His people.

“I am your King, by blood and by oath. I accepted your loyalty once, and no force in this world could break that bond between you and I. I am your King, and I will not run nor hide from my responsibilities any longer.”

They stirred. Flos stood taller. His voice grew louder.

“I have no right to ask it of you. No right at all. But twenty long years have passed since I slumbered and the world has not changed. There is still little hope to cling to. People live and die in service to a faceless [Lord], struggle to eat and live, sleep in fear of monsters and bandits. This is not the way to live. There is a better life out there, beyond the horizon.”

He turned and Trey saw his eyes. They were burning. Flos stared from person to person, looking into their faces. They stared back, caught by his gaze.

“Come with me. Follow my back. Raise my banner one more time. One last time. This time, I shall not retreat. I shall not falter. I will go to the ends of the world and tear down every wall, every fortress of stone. You are not the villagers of Manimar, not the people of one single farm or village. You are mine. You are my people, and I ask you again. Join me. Your King has a dream. Will you follow me?”

For a while no one moved. And then a woman stood up.

“I will, my King.”

An old man was next. He smiled, tears in his eyes.

“We have waited for this day, your Majesty.”

“We are with you! Until the end!”

More people jumped to their feet. Young and old. They stood up, shouting and cheering. Trey looked around the room, and then realized he was on his feet. So was Teres. They gathered around Flos, reaching out to touch him.

Someone had a flag. It was old, a relic over two decades old, eaten away by time and rot. But when Flos touched it, the colors came to life. A black flag, stitched with gold around the edges. Trey stared up at it. There was something in the center of the flag.

It was a flame. A burning flame, woven out of gold and silver, white and purple, a flame that burned brightest in the dark. It flew above the wall as people cheered and called Flos’ name. He stared up at the banner and smiled.

The sun began to rise as, in the village of Manimar, people lit torches and gathered around their King. They had not forgotten their King. And he had never forgotten them.

Trey found himself standing with Teres. She was staring at Flos, head propped in her hands, dreamily. He sat with her.

They didn’t need to speak. They sat and watched Flos, at the center of the world, accepting people’s vows, talking with them. And Trey thought he understood how someone could follow him and keep faith with him after two decades. It was because when you listened to him, you could believe there was a better place just over that mountaintop. And you would fight for it. You could follow him for that dream.

Trey turned to look towards that horizon. His eyes found the lightening sky, and the hint of a sun in the distance. And past that the hills...

Trey frowned. He stood up and Teres turned. Something was coming. Flashes of light reflected off of armor, riders. Orthenon? Someone from

Reim? Trey's heart beat wildly. He had never seen that armor, nor the banners raised. There were two dozen riders, at least. And more—behind them Trey saw more moving shapes.

An army. Marching towards the village.

He turned to call the alarm. But someone had already seen the riders. They shouted. Flos turned. The villagers tried to close the gates, but there were too many people in the way. Trey heard screams, and the thunder of hoof beats. He saw the first rider race into the village, scattering people out of the way.

The man on horseback pulled his horse to a stop in front of Flos. The King didn't move. He stared up at the armored man, wearing light chainmail armor the color of silver. He had a shield on his back and a sword at his side.

The man looked coldly down at Flos. The King stared up at him and smiled once.

“Venith Crusland. It has been a long time since I last saw your face.”

“King Flos Reimarch.”

There was no love in the man's voice. He stared down at Flos as the other riders rode in through the gates. Flos nodded, looking around at the other riders without fear, but sadness in his eyes.

“I had heard you became lord of this village and these lands. Tell me, you who once rode with me. Do you come to fight by my side again, old friend?”

Venith shook his head. He stared down at Flos, and Trey saw the anger there. The anger and something else. He reached for his sword and drew it slowly. The other riders did the same.

“No. I have come for your head.”

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“Flos of Reim. I have come for your head.”

The young man lying on the ground looked up. He stared in vague surprise at the other young man on horseback. His eyes fixed first on Venith’s set face and clenched jaw. Only then did he focus on the sword in Venith’s left hand.

He sat up and yawned, but didn’t reply to Venith’s statement. He scratched the back of his head and shook loose some of the dirt that had gotten trapped there. Of all the things Venith had expected, this wasn’t it.

He drew his horse closer, cursing a bit as his mare seemed more interested in Flos’ stallion, which was placidly eating a few whippy plants to the left. Venith glared down at the king of Reim, Flos. He didn’t seem like much to Venith. He was bigger than the young man on horseback, but Venith had beaten grown men far larger.

“Did you hear me? I said—”

“I heard you.”

Flos looked up at Venith, not intimidated the least by the sword the other man held. The young king had a sword, Venith could see. But he didn’t reach for it.

“Well?”

“I’m thinking.”

That was all the young man with bright red-gold hair said. He stared at Venith, frowning as if the young man were a puzzle, rather than an enemy.

That was too much for Venith’s pride. He lifted his sword.

“Have you any last words before I cut you apart?”

“I’m rather wondering why you didn’t do it earlier, actually.”

“What?”

Flos sprang to his feet, so quickly Venith cursed and pulled his horse back. He rode backwards as the king mused to himself out loud.

“It’s strange. If you were another [Assassin], or a [Bounty Hunter] or [Mercenary], or any one of the people who’ve come to claim my head this month, you’d have tried to sneak up and stab me to death, or blast me with a spell at range. Or use an arrow. Or poison. But you didn’t. You rode up and told me you were going to kill me.”

“So? I’m a [Warrior]. Are you going to draw your sword or not?”

Venith didn’t know why he was replying when he should have been attacking. But Flos just grinned as if he knew.

“If I didn’t, would you cut me down? Unarmed?”

“Yes!”

“No, I don’t think you would. Else, you’d have ridden at me and not given me time to prepare.”

That was true. Venith knew he *should* have done that, and he flushed angrily. But Flos just smiled.

“So you’re coming to take my head? Why?”

“My reasons are my own. I’m challenging you, King of Reim. Are you a coward, or will you answer me with steel?”

Venith raised his voice and shouted down at the young man. Flos sighed. He reached for his side and drew his sword. Venith tensed.

“Well?”

Flos looked mystified.

“Well, what?”

“Get on your stallion.”

The young King looked over at where his stallion had gone to graze. He shook his head.

“I don’t feel like it. I’ll fight you on foot. It won’t make a difference either way.”

“What?”

Venith stared down at Flos. He felt unbalanced. The young king of Reim, the boy with eight thousand gold pieces on his head dead and twice that alive, grinned as he spread his arms.

“Shouldn’t you be glad? I’ve heard a mounted [Rider] can defeat three [Soldiers] of the same level.”

That was just a rumor. Venith had heard the same thing boasted of, but since he was no [Rider] he’d never want to try that. He stared down with narrowed eyes at Flos. He wasn’t what Venith had expected at all. He hadn’t tried to beg for his life, or flee for safety. Part of Venith couldn’t help but admire the King for his confidence.

But he was here to kill the young man. That made everything harder. After a second of furious internal debate, Venith swung himself off his horse. He set his mare running with a slap on her side as he grabbed the shield he always carried. It was flat along the top and curved downwards to a point at the bottom. A heater shield. This one didn’t have Venith’s heraldry on it. It, like his sword, was unmarked, so no one would know his identity when the deed was done.

Flos eyed Venith as the young man approached, keeping his shield up.

“You needn’t have done that.”

“Shut up. I’m better without my horse. Now, are you going to fight?”

Venith was angry without knowing why. He didn’t want to do this, but he had to. He wished he’d never spoken. But to his surprise, the young Flos just grinned.

“As you like. I am Flos of Reim! What’s your name?”

It was too late to go back. Venith shouted over the thundering of his heart.

“Venith Crusland! Prepare to die!”

He charged, ready to end it in a single thrust. But Flos raised his sword and Venith, forewarned, raised his shield. He felt something *crash* into his shield and staggered. He raised his sword, but Flos was already running past him. Venith spun, and heard a strange noise over the blood pumping in his veins. It was laughter. Flos was laughing—

Five minutes later, Venith lay on the ground. He couldn't move. Part of the armor around his legs was damaged and unable to bend. And his right hand felt broken. He stared up at the blue, clear sky while he heard footsteps crunching in the dirt, coming towards him.

"I told you it wouldn't make a difference."

Venith closed his eyes. He refused to cry, or beg. He tried to speak and coughed.

"Finish me off already."

"Why?"

Someone reached down and hauled Venith up. The young man found himself being carried to the slight incline where he'd first laid eyes on Flos. The young king dropped Venith there, and Venith stared up at him.

"If you plan on torturing me to find out where I come from—"

"Don't be silly. I like you. And I don't care where you come from. I just want to know why you came to kill me."

Flos grinned down at Venith. He was barely sweating. Venith stared up at him.

"I needed the bounty on your head. That's all."

He felt ashamed for saying it. It wasn't an honorable thing to do. But Venith was no [Knight]. He had duties. He was ready for Flos to scorn him, but the young king only laughed.

"That's why you tried to kill me? Just for money? Then it's no wonder you lost!"

That stung. Venith tried to rise and fell back.

"I had a chance! I waited until you were alone. If I'd attacked from behind—"

"You still would have lost. I can't be killed by [Assassins], you see. I have a friend—well, a vassal, really. She would have killed you, but I told her to let you come closer."

"A vassal?"

Venith looked around stupidly, but he hadn't seen anyone when he'd approached Flos. The king just smiled.

"You might have beaten me, it's true, but not with a bad reason like that."

He laughed again. It was beginning to get on Venith's nerves.

"What do you mean?"

The boy King stopped laughing and regarded Venith, suddenly serious.

"If your reason isn't good enough, there's no way you'd ever best me. I have a dream as large as all of Chandrar. If yours isn't at least half as big, you'll never be able to beat me."

"What? That's stupid."

"It's not. I'll never die so long as I have my dream. That's why I knew I could beat you."

Flos stared down at the other young man. He offered Venith a hand again. After a moment of hesitation, Venith took it.

"You're nothing like what I've heard."

"Oh?"

"I heard you were a fool who accepted traitors and slaves into his kingdom. A rabble rouser with no respect for law or tradition."

"That's partly true. But it doesn't matter."

"Why not?"

Flos spread his arms wide, grinning broadly with a smile that was infectious.

"I am a King. If I cared what people thought, I'd really be a fool, wouldn't I?"

Venith stared at him. He wasn't like any [King] Venith had ever met, not that he'd had a chance to talk to any other one. He'd only glimpsed other monarchs from afar, usually on bended knee or while dining at a feast or banquet. But Flos was different.

“So if you won’t kill me, what will you do? My family...cannot afford to pay a ransom if that’s what you’re hoping.”

“I don’t want that either. I think I’ll just let you go.”

Flos turned and whistled as Venith gaped. One horse came running. Venith’s mare. Flos stared at his stallion and kicked at the dirt irritably. Then he smiled again as Venith staggered over to his mare.

“When you have a better reason for fighting, come find me again. That was fun.”

The other young man made no reply. He hauled himself up into the saddle, wincing. He wheeled his mare to stare at Flos. Then he shook his head.

“You aren’t worth my time.”

Venith spurred his mare and rode away as he heard the young man named Flos howl with laughter. At that moment, Venith *hated* that sound. But he would hear it for many more years and smile. Until the day the laughter stopped...

Laughter. It was fierce, loud, and unexpected. It made Trey jolt as he stared at Flos. The King of Destruction was *laughing* at the man who’d spoken. Venith Crusland.

It made everyone stare. The villagers, crowded protectively around their King, the mounted warriors, even the man with the sword. He wore a helmet with no visor, allowing Trey to see his face. Venith was an older man, around Flos’ age. He had dark hair, and a stern, set face. He held a shield on his right hand, and a drawn sword in his left. But Flos only laughed at him. He laughed and laughed, as if he’d heard a truly hilarious joke, not a threat against his life.

When he finished, there was silence. Flos wiped tears from his eyes, and then stared up at the mounted man, his smile fading. Venith Crusland hadn’t moved, and his eyes hadn’t shifted from Flos’ face.

“Memory is a strange thing, Venith. Do you have a better reason for seeking my life this time?”

The man on the warhorse stared down at Flos, cold emotions locked behind his eyes.

“Peace for my people. Vengeance, and retribution for an oathbreaker. And an end to your lies.”

Flos sighed. His shoulders slumped slightly, and he stared at Venith with disappointment. Disappointment, and something else. Regret, Trey thought. Or was it guilt?

“Oh? I had hoped to see you before now, Venith. I thought you would be the first to ride through my gates. I waited for you long, old friend.”

“You would have had to wait forever. I did not rejoice to hear you had awakened. And if you had the sense to stay clear of my lands, you would not have forced my hand.”

Venith raised his sword slightly. Flos stared at it.

“You are serious.”

“I do not forgive betrayal. And I swore an oath to take arms against you should you ever wake from your slumber.”

Now Venith rode forwards. He motioned slightly with his shield, and the other mounted soldiers spread out with him. They drew their weapons as well. But...hesitantly. Trey saw one armored warrior riding next to Venith fumble before raising a spear.

Venith didn't seem to notice. The [Lord] stared at the mob of villagers surrounding Flos.

“Move aside.”

“No, my Lord Venith!”

A man moved to bar Venith's way. He stared pleadingly up at the [Lord].

“Our King has returned, don't you see? How could you raise your sword against him?”

Trey heard more voices raised in agreement around him. Venith stared as the villagers moved to protect their King, forming a living wall between him and Flos. His face twisted with fury.

“Silence! You are not his subjects. You are mine! I am your [Lord]! I have ruled you for twenty years!”

“But I am their [King].”

Flos strode forwards. The people around him parted unwillingly, but they did move. Flos stood at the head of the villagers, staring up at Venith without fear.

“Pull your warriors back, Venith. The people of Manimar are not tainted by my guilt.”

“Then send them away and face me yourself, coward.”

“No.”

Trey saw Venith blink incredulously. But Flos was calm as he went on.

“I will not let myself die here. But neither will I order my subjects to a slaughter. And neither will you. You are not that sort of man, Venith.”

“You do not know me.”

The [King] met the [Lord]’s eyes steadily.

“Yes. I do. You will not slaughter innocent people here. Pull your forces back and we will settle this in a duel, Venith.”

For a second, Trey thought Venith might order his men to attack. His face was red with fury, but he eventually growled a command. He wheeled his horse and the others did likewise.

All except for one. The rider holding the spear was staring at Flos. Trey had an uneasy feeling. He fought to get closer and realized Teres wasn’t at his side. Where had she gone?

Then his head turned as he heard her voice.

“Look out!”

Teres was standing near the edge of the crowd. She had something in her hands. She hurled it as the mounted rider kicked his horse forwards.

She'd thrown a stone, but it was too late. The mounted warrior was shouting as he aimed his spear at Flos' chest.

"Die, King of Destruction!"

He ducked the thrown rock and raised his spear to impale Flos. The King stared at the rider as he charged at him. He seemed to sigh.

The spear shot forwards as the rider thrust with it. But it stopped as Flos reached out and *grabbed* the shaft. He didn't budge, and as the horse continued forwards the spear was locked between the two. The warrior *slammed* into his saddle and then tumbled off it as his mount's forward momentum tried to carry him forwards and the spear held him back.

He tumbled off the horse and landed hard on the ground with a *crash* of armor. At once, the villagers were upon him. Enraged by the attack, they began kicking and stomping on him as he tried to get up.

"Calac!"

Someone shouted that name amid the roars of anger as the rest of the villagers streamed towards the downed warrior. Trey turned his head and saw Venith was riding back, sword in hand. The villagers scattered as he rode through them, striking with the flat of his sword and knocking men and women away.

He dismounted and reached for the fallen figure. At once, the villagers were around him. Venith turned, sword and shield ready, but it was Flos who strode forwards. He stopped the villagers from descending on the two warriors.

"Enough. Let him go."

"But your Majesty—"

"Let him go. "

Reluctantly, the people backed away. Flos stared down at Venith; the man was a head shorter than him. Then his eyes went to the warrior who'd tried to kill him. He was still helmeted, but Trey thought he was a younger man.

"Is that your son, Venith? I remember the name. Calac. You wrote to me the day he was born, and I drank to his health. I am happy he is grown, even

if his manners are lacking.”

“He is my son. And a fool.”

For all his harsh words, Venith carefully carried his son to his horse. He helped Calac to mount as a second mounted soldier brought a second horse over to Venith. Flos called out to him as Venith put one foot in his stirrups.

“I have never seen his face.”

Venith’s head turned. He did not look grateful. There was fury in his eyes. Fury and dark hatred.

“And you never will.”

He kicked his mount in the sides and he rode out of the village without looking back. Flos watched him go as people shouted curses at Venith’s back. He somehow found Trey, trying to push towards him in the crowd. Flos sighed. And then he rolled his shoulder and stood tall. Because he was a King.

When they were outside of the village and riding towards the rest of the soldiers Venith had brought, he stopped and turned to his son. Calac had taken off his helm, and his face was pale as he rode next to his father. He was bruised on his right cheek and his armor had been dented in places by the villagers.

Venith didn’t waste time with words. He slapped his son across the face with one hand. It wasn’t a heavy blow, but with his gauntlets on it drew blood.

“You *idiot*.”

Calac’s face was red with embarrassment.

“Father, I could have—”

“You have disgraced yourself and your family’s name! Be silent!”

There was too much memory and guilt in his eyes. Venith turned away as he guided his horse towards his forces. A rank of cavalry waited for him,

along with a cluster of armed foot soldiers and archers. But not his [Mage], nor the vast majority of his forces. They had stayed behind rather than take up arms against the man that had been their King.

His mood was black. Venith had no ears for the man who rode up alongside, asking for orders.

“Keep your forces back. Encircle the village, but do not attack, even if provoked.”

“What if he runs? The King?”

Calac flinched as Venith looked at him. For a second his father struggled with the urge to shout, but he controlled his temper. Barely.

“He will not run. Even if he is a shadow of what he was, that man would not run.”

“But what if he does?”

Too stubborn, and too insolent. Venith felt like he was staring at himself, twenty years ago. He scowled.

“If he does, I will run him down.”

“But if we attacked—”

That was too much. Venith shouted at his son, the first time he had done so in public.

“I will *not* slaughter my people! And if you draw your sword without my permission again, I will disown you. *Is that understood?*”

Calac’s face went white. He stood still and nodded. Venith turned away.

“We are not without honor, even if he is an oathbreaker. And if we attacked, we would be the ones feeding the crows.”

His soldiers stirred. The younger ones, those who hadn’t ever known the King of Destruction as more than a slumbering legend, looked incredulous. The older ones knew better.

“Don’t underestimate an army of villagers. Don’t underestimate him. He could cut you apart with ease, and he has the Skills to make any battle even. No. I’ll kill him myself.”

Venith turned. It wasn't his son he looked at, but his oldest retainers. The ones who'd fought with him over two decades ago. They shifted. Some were uneasy. Others wavered. But some had the same anger that burned in Venith's heart. They understood.

Venith dismounted from his horse.

"Alert me when the King of Destruction moves. It won't be long."

He drew his sword and inspected it. Venith knew it was undamaged; he'd sharpened the blade this very morning. And the same went for his shield. But he wanted to take no chances.

One of his men rode towards the village to keep watch on it. The burning torches made visibility hard, but Venith knew the King would not run. He wouldn't. Even as weak as he was, he would not. And so he would come out, and Venith would make him pay for betrayal.

The man's hands shook as he lifted his shield. He stared at the village, trying to summon more of the white-hot fury that had gripped him when he'd heard the words he'd despaired of hearing ever again. But there wasn't any anger when he reached for it. Just a kind of emptiness—no, a lack of anything at all. He reached into his chest and felt nothing at all.

So it was with a kind of dread that Venith stood, waiting for his King. He stared at the village and remembered another sight, one far more bitter than the time they had first met.

How had it gone? A village and a King. Only the village that Venith saw in his head had no wall. It was dark, and the village was burning. He could still smell the smoke, taste the blood and fear in his mouth. His grip loosened on his sword.

Once.

The second time Venith met Flos, he was galloping away from his father's castle as it burned in the distance. The village was filled with screams and armed soldiers striking down people—his people as he fled.

They cried out for someone to save them, but Venith could not stop. Sixteen riders wearing black armor and the silver insignia of a set of scales on their arms were in hot pursuit of him.

They caught him at the bridge. Venith heard his mare scream as she stumbled. He tumbled to the ground and saw an arrow in her thigh. His faithful horse thrashed on the ground as Venith tried to get to his feet.

Too slow.

“Put down your sword, Venith Crusland. Accept your judgment.”

The leader of the pursuers was female, but her face was covered by a black veil. She, like the others, hid her face. They surrounded him, weapons raised. Venith reached for his shield, but he had dropped it. So he clasped both hands to his sword and told himself he would kill one of them before he died.

“Hold.”

The voice didn’t come from in front of Venith, but rather, behind. He turned warily, and saw his pursuers back away. Because they were outnumbered.

Flos had changed little in the year since Venith had tried to kill him. He was a tiny bit taller, that was all. But this time he was not alone. An army stood at his back. The army of Reim, just as Venith had heard.

For a second hope surged in his breast. But then Venith felt movement. He whipped around and felt something touch the skin at his neck.

A glaive’s tip cut into his throat. The woman who held it stared past him, at Flos.

“Withdraw your forces, King of Reim. This does not concern you.”

“Put up your blade. Now. I know that man. Why are you trying to kill him?”

It wasn’t a question that needed asking. Venith knew Flos must have known. The woman’s response was sharp and irritated as she raised her glaive away from Venith’s head. He felt at his throat and felt blood.

“We are the Black Judgment. The house of Crusland has failed to honor its debts and refused to pay its dues. We are administering justice.”

“You mean they refused to sell their people off as slaves. And now you’re killing all of them.”

“Oathbreakers shall be punished. Criminals shall be found. Traitors slain. You know we answer to no [Monarch]. Do not interfere.”

Flos was staring at Venith. His eyes flicked to the village. Venith could still hear screaming. The Black Judgment worked methodically, going from house to house. They did not have to hurry. They just had to ensure no one escaped.

“My lord. They have many soldiers here.”

A quiet, frightened voice came from one of the people standing next to Flos. He turned his head.

“How many, Gazi?”

“A thousand—perhaps a thousand five hundred. All armored. And six mages.”

Overkill for a small [Lord]’s house and his retainers. But that was how the Black Judgment worked. Anyone who broke the law and refused to honor their debts was punished, be it a [King] or a [Beggar]. Venith’s stomach twisted. Now that he looked, he saw the army that accompanied Flos was no true army. Their numbers lay in the hundreds, possibly not coming close to a thousand.

He stared dully at the woman—no, the person who’d spoken. She was not Human. He found himself staring at a being with a huge eye in the center of her head and four smaller ones around it. He only vaguely recognized her as a species from Baleros. A Gazer.

She was female, frightened, holding a sword that looked too big for her. Venith looked around. The rest of Flos’ ‘army’ looked the same. They weren’t the professional soldiers he’d expected, merely the sons and daughters of [Farmers] and [Shopkeepers]. Common peasantry.

He turned away in despair. His father had sent [Messages] for help in every direction. If Flos hadn’t come with an army three times larger, it meant he was only here to watch.

But the King was arguing with the half-Gazer now. He stared hard at the soldiers as he spoke to her.

“I like him, Gazi. And these aren’t soldiers that are being killed.”

Venith looked incredulously at Flos. The leader of the band of Black Judgment warriors was doing the same. Flos spurred his mount forwards until he was sitting and looking down at Venith.

“So this is why you came for my head. It is still not a good enough reason.”

There was no point to talking. Venith lowered his head, biting his lip until he tasted blood.

“Go on and leave. You can’t do anything here.”

“I could. This does not seem like justice to my eyes.”

Flos leaned forwards on his mount. He was staring at the burning village. The woman with the glaive spoke sharply.

“You have no right! This is the law and they have broken it!”

The King of Reim ignored her completely. He looked at Venith.

“I have no cause. A King must not declare war for no reason. But perhaps you have one. Is this just?”

He would have loved to say yes. He would have loved to deny the truth. But Venith’s hand clenched on his sword’s hilt until it cracked. He spoke slowly.

“My father borrowed too much and refused to sell his people. That is the truth. This is—justice.”

“I see. You are a poor liar.”

Flos didn’t move as Venith whirled on him. He was staring at the village. He pointed.

“Look, Venith Crusland. Over there. That girl.”

Venith did not want to look. But he did. He saw a child lying on the ground. She was dead. Dead, or soon to be dead. He looked down.

“What about her?”

“What is her name?”

“Don’t *mock*—”

A hand reached down and lifted Venith *off* the ground. Flos stared at Venith as his stallion groaned at the sudden increase in weight.

“What. Is. Her. Name?”

Venith turned to look. There was no way he could tell at a distance—

His breath caught. He saw a long braid, faintly blonde hair. He remembered the handful of flowers that she gathered every summer and handed out like they were treasures. He spoke her name.

“Merisa.”

The King dropped him. Venith landed on the ground with a thump. Flos nodded. He stared at the village, and then met the eyes of the order of Black Judgment.

“That’s all I needed to know.”

He rode back towards Gazi, and his army of amateur warriors. Venith lowered his head and raised his sword as the Black Judgment closed in. Then he heard Flos’ voice.

“Her name is *Merisa!*”

It was a shout. Like thunder, his voice echoed across the ground, cutting above the screaming and shouts. Venith saw Flos turn. Then the young King unsheathed his sword. Beside him, the half-Gazer raised her blade.

Flos pointed straight at the woman with the glaive. He uttered one word.

“*Charge!*”

His army roared and swept forwards. Venith heard thundering hooves, and then Flos leapt past him. He cut the first warrior of the Black Judgment down and then rode on. Shouting a child’s name.

That was the first time Venith had ever wept in public. He ran after the King of Reim on the day he declared war against the Black Judgment.

For a child.

For justice.

“Teres!”

Trey shouted her name amid the clamor around him. He heard someone shout his name, and then found her in the sea of people.

“Over here!”

She led him away, away from Flos, who was at the center of the throng of people. When they could talk without shouting, Trey hugged Teres. She hugged him back.

“How’d you know he was going to do that?”

“I didn’t. But when he didn’t ride off I got a bad feeling.”

“You threw a rock at him! What if he stabbed you?”

“He didn’t.”

Trey opened his mouth to protest that logic when he heard his name again.

“Teres. *Trey!*”

Someone’s voice boomed. The twins turned. Flos was striding towards them, the sea of people parting in biblical fashion. The King smiled as he stared at Teres.

“You have keen eyes, Teres. A shame you had no bow or wand. I will fix that another time. For now, follow me.”

He turned. The twins stared at each other and then followed Flos. He was walking towards the village gates. People were trying to stop him without actually holding him back. A man—the village headman, perhaps, was trying to talk to Flos.

“Don’t go alone, my King. We’ll follow you into battle! We might not have weapons, most of us, but we’ve a wall and three times their number. We’ll choke them on our blood and flesh if need be!”

“That would be the worst outcome. Far worse than my death. Venith is your [Lord], is he not?”

“Yes, but—”

“But nothing. He is a good [Lord], by all accounts. I remember Orthenon telling me he patrolled these lands. For twenty years he has kept you safe from monsters and brigands.”

“He is not you, my King. And he was once your vassal! Taking arms against his sword master is treason!”

“Perhaps. But I was the one who betrayed him first.”

Flos sighed. He did not look at the confused headman, but turned to the twins.

“I will duel Venith now. The sun should rise shortly—stand with your backs to it so you may have the best view.”

They gaped at him. Teres was the first to find her voice.

“Why?”

“He challenged me. That is how things are done in this land.”

“Not that! Why does he hate you? Was he your vassal?”

“Yes. And he bears a grudge.”

Flos strode out of the village, people streaming after him. He was adjusting his belt, tightening it. Trey stared at Flos. He wasn’t wearing armor.

“Why does he hate you?”

“For abandoning him? For leaving my kingdom to rot? For incompetence, failure, cowardice?”

The King of Destruction shook his head.

“I do not know. But I must answer him, Trey. I cannot run from my failure. And he has every right to hate me.”

“But he’s wearing *armor*! And you’ve only got a sword!”

“Yes. I rather wish I had something else.”

Instantly a hundred voices rose, offering Flos a shield, a helmet that might fit, a piece of armor. He waved the voices away.

“I have no need. And Venith will not wait. Besides, a sword is all I need.”

He unsheathed his sword, and Trey stared hopefully at the blade. But it did not glow, or sparkle. It was shiny, but that was only because moonlight shone on it.

Flos saw Trey's expression and laughed.

"There is no enchantment on the blade, Trey. I believe I took this one from my armory. It is just steel. But it is my sword, so it is a King's sword. That should be good enough, even for Venith."

"But he's got *armor*."

Teres stared at Flos and then grabbed Trey's arm.

"He's not listening to me. Talk sense to him!"

"I'm trying!"

"And I am listening. But your worries are unfounded, Teres. I will not lose. Because I am a King."

Trey's sister gaped at Flos' back. But at his words a huge cheer went up from the people who had heard. Flos stopped and turned to face the villagers.

"I have been challenged! And so I declare this: I will go to do battle with Lord Venith Crusland. Let no one interfere with our duel on pain of death!"

They shouted and cheered him. A King wearing no armor about to fight a man in full plate armor with a sword and shield. Trey stared at Flos as he strode across the dry, flat ground.

Venith was waiting for him. The man stood braced, ready for battle. His soldiers had spread out around him, forming a large semicircle. Flos halted with the crowd of villagers at his back. He stared at Venith, and then turned his back on the man. He raised his empty left hand and bellowed into the night.

"People of Manimar! Who is your rightful ruler?"

A roar answered him.

"Flos!"

He raised his sword, and the cheering and shouting from the villagers overwhelmed all other sound. Venith waited, braced in the dirt, shield in one hand, sword aimed at Flos' chest.

Trey found himself standing closest to Flos, in the circle that watched the two about to duel. Teres was by his side. She was gripping his arm so hard it hurt, but Trey was doing the same to her.

This was crazy. Insane. But there was something to this moment that spoke to Trey. He thought of knights. Of honor and valor and chivalry. And when he looked at Venith he thought about vengeance and betrayal.

Flos strode towards Venith and stopped around ten paces away. When he spoke, it was far more quietly, so that Trey had to strain to hear over the restless crowd.

"Why is it that you cannot bear that I live, Venith? You, who once fought beside me fiercest of all?"

"Because you abandoned us."

Venith raised his sword. Flos kept his lowered. The man charged and the duel began without a signal.

From where he stood, Trey could barely see Venith's sword flash forwards. He'd stabbed at Flos' chest, but Flos stepped sideways incredibly quickly. His sword came up and parried Venith's thrust with the flat of his blade, knocking it aside.

Venith spun as Flos turned. He lashed out, punching with his shield. Flos stepped back from that as well, and raised his sword. Venith pulled his shield up and braced. The sword came down.

And Trey felt the *clash* in his bones. Venith staggered. He stabbed with his sword again and Flos dodged. The King cut horizontally at Venith's side and the blade slashed across Venith's shield. Then Flos reversed the direction of his cut. He was aiming for Venith's shoulder. But Venith had raised his shield again. This time the noise made several people clap their hands to their ears.

"Your skill hasn't changed, Venith. Your [Flawless Defence] is still as invincible as ever."

He said it so casually, as if he weren't fighting for his life. But Venith's voice was tense, filled with sharp emotions.

"I haven't put down my sword for twenty years. Unlike you. And you have grown weak."

He raised his shield as Flos leapt forwards. The King jerked his head back to avoid having it clipped by Venith's shield. He retreated as Venith slashed at him.

The [Lord] didn't fight like Trey expected. He never slashed wide with his sword and always kept it close to his body. When he attacked it was with a quick, precise cut, not Flos' powerful strikes. He kept advancing on the King, not giving Flos a chance to move around and find his back.

He was forcing Flos to defend, but Trey saw that Flos could easily parry most of Venith's strikes, even when the man tried to strike him with the rim of his shield. By the same token though, Venith's cautious style meant that every time Flos tried to strike him, his shield was in the way.

But the *sound* of it. Trey shuddered as Flos struck Venith again and the very air seemed to explode. Flos was clearly stronger than Venith, and only the man's shield held him at bay. Around him the villagers of Manimar were shouting their King's name, drowning out the soldiers who cheered for their lord, Venith.

The noise of it was deafening, actually drowning out most of the sounds of battle, save for when Flos dealt Venith a strong blow. But Trey could still hear the two shouting at each other, in a world of their own as they fought in the center of the ring of onlookers.

"You are mine, Venith!"

Flos shouted at the man as he cut rapidly from every side, trying to score a solid blow. But Venith's shield moved just as quickly, deflecting every strike.

"You are not my king!"

Venith roared as he cut low at Flos' leg. This time the King had to jump away. He was nearly struck as Venith lashed out. Trey saw the sword catch on part of Flos' royal clothing.

"A king who abandoned his kingdom is not a [King]! He is a coward!"

Venith lashed out with the edge of his shield. Flos had to avoid that; he blocked Venith's sword with his, suddenly being pushed back. Venith charged forwards.

"You left us to rot! You left us to die!"

"Yes."

Flos cut down, like lightning. Venith raised his shield. Again metal met metal. Trey blinked from the impact—he felt there should have been sparks. But then he saw something as Venith cut again, forcing Flos back.

Flos' sword was *bent*. It was so slight Trey might not have noticed it. But then he saw Flos strike out with it and knew that he wasn't seeing things.

"Trey—"

Teres had seen the same thing. Flos' strength might outmatch Venith, but his sword couldn't handle the abuse. And as Trey saw Venith force Flos back, he realized Venith knew this too.

Flos didn't know. Or he didn't care. He kept striking at Venith's guard, as if to batter him down with sheer force. But his sword slowly and steadily deformed from the impacts.

The breaking point came when Flos charged Venith, locking his blade against the man's shield. He tried to cut below around it, but Venith was too quick. He raised his sword up and brought it down on the bent part of Flos' blade.

Just steel. That was what Flos' sword was made of. But Venith's was enchanted, or better quality. Or simply stronger. It bit slightly into the blade. Flos twisted away and stared at his blade. Venith gritted his teeth. He raised his shield as the King brought down his blade.

For the last time.

The blade met the shield. Only this time there was no *crash* of impact. Flos' sword broke as it met the shield. It didn't shatter, but the blade *snapped* and spiraled into the air.

Silence followed that moment, as Flos stared down at the handle of his broken sword. Venith smiled grimly and raised his shield and sword as he

spoke.

“And a king without a sword is nothing.”

Flos took a step back. Trey stared around in horror at the ring of watching villagers. They were no longer cheering.

“You are no match for me without a sword.”

Venith strode forwards, and this time Flos was in full retreat. The King cast aside the hilt of his sword.

“My King!”

Someone shouted. Trey saw a man waving a sword in his hands, trying to throw it to Flos. But the King ignored the blade as Venith’s soldiers pulled the man back into the crowd.

“What now, King of Destruction?”

There was mockery in Venith’s tone, but it was bitter. And he was not smiling. He looked as if he was in pain as he slowly backed Flos towards where Trey and Teres stood. Flos danced out of range, far quicker than any man his size should have moved.

“Your vassals will not return. Your kingdom is in ruins. Your lands are gone. You have nothing left. You are no King! You have no army, no allies, no sword—”

“*Silence.*”

Venith’s eyes widened. He raised his shield and a fist crashed into it. Trey heard the dull *thump*. Venith stumbled back. He raised his sword and a foot kicked him in his armored chest. He fell backwards, crashing onto the ground.

Flos stood over him. He shook his right hand, and raised his voice as he pointed down at Venith.

“Fool! Have you learned nothing of Kings?”

Everyone stared at him as Venith struggled to get up. Flos raised his right fist into the air; Trey saw the skin along his knuckles had split from the impact. It was bleeding.

“A King is more than just a *sword*! He is more than a crown, more than an army or a kingdom. Deny it if you will, Venith. But I am and always will be your [King]. Nothing will change that!”

Venith got to his feet, coughing. He swung at Flos with his sword, slower. Flos grabbed his gauntleted arm.

“A *King* cannot be beaten by any common warrior!”

He caught Venith’s shield as it flew towards his face. Flos held Venith’s arms apart as the man struggled to free himself. Then Flos’ head drew back.

Venith was wearing a steel helmet. Flos was not. The King’s head came down and struck Venith on the helmeted forehead so hard Trey winced. Venith stumbled back. Flos took three steps back and shook his head like a dog. But he was the first one to step forwards.

“A King is always a King. And I am *your King*!”

The [Lord] groggily raised his sword. He blinked and saw Flos striding towards him. Venith tried to raise his shield, but it was too late.

Flos’ right fist met the front of Venith’s helm. The impact sent the man’s head snapping back. Trey saw Venith stagger. He took a step back and then slowly collapsed back onto the ground.

Blood dripped from Flos’ right hand. The metal faceguard on Venith’s helm was stained red with blood, but not from the man. It had cut deep into Flos’ hand. But the King didn’t appear to notice. He looked down at the fallen [Lord].

“I will always be your King, Venith.”

The man made no reply. He might have been unconscious. The King turned away. He bent down and picked up Venith’s sword out of the dirt.

Now everyone was silent. Trey stared at Flos as the King walked back to Venith. The rush of excitement and fear in his veins had turned completely to horror. What would happen now?

There was only one thing Trey could think of. Flos stared down sadly at Venith. He raised the sword in his hands. Trey’s mouth was dry with fear.

“No!”

Someone shouted in the circle of onlookers. Trey saw a young man without a helmet—the same one who’d attacked Flos with the spear.

Calac. He threw himself in front of his father, arms spread wide.

“Have mercy, sire!”

Other people rushed to hold him back. Not just villagers—soldiers as well. Flos watched them pull Calac away, and then turned his head. Trey and Teres were standing by his side, staring at the sword in his hands. Their faces were pale.

“Are you going to—”

Flos didn’t immediately reply. He looked back at Calac. Trey saw the young man’s face, darker than his father’s, but with the same features. Flos stared too.

“I wished to see his son’s face, you know. But I was too far from home.”

He turned back to Venith. Then Flos’ head turned. He frowned and then threw a hand out. Trey felt a palm knock him off his feet. He heard Teres cry out in shock, and then a *thunk*.

Trey sat up and saw the arrow. It had passed through the air where Flos’ arm had been. If Flos hadn’t turned, and if he hadn’t knocked Trey out of the way, it would have struck Trey’s leg.

“Who—what was that?”

Teres was shouting. Most of the people around Flos hadn’t heard or seen the arrow, focused as they were on Calac, who was struggling and shouting with the people who held him. But Flos’ head turned. He looked east, towards the brighter sky.

“His wife.”

Someone was standing on a hilltop to the east. It was a thousand feet in the distance, yet Trey could see the figure clearly. She was riding a horse. Her hair was short, but the figure was unmistakably a woman.

And she was holding a bow. A woman on a horse put another arrow to the huge bow she carried. She was a distant speck, but when she loosed the second arrow it sped towards Flos’ chest.

He cut the second arrow out of the air. Flos stepped sideways casually and Trey heard the *ripping* sound of cut air before the shaft splintered into two parts. One spun past Trey's face and something stung his cheek.

"Lady Maresar disapproves of our duel."

"Is she going to shoot us?"

"No, I think."

Teres stared at the figure in the distance. She was raising another arrow to her bow. But Flos turned away. He didn't appear concerned.

"What are you doing? She's going to shoot you!"

"I see her. But I see someone else as well. She is always about. I should have known she would have noticed me."

"Who?"

Trey stared at the hill. The woman named Maresar was sitting on her horse. But there was someone else? Then he saw her, blending in at the bottom of the hill. If she hadn't moved, he would never have seen her. But that was why she wore that armor. It matched her skin, and it was the color of dirt. Now the half-Gazer strode up the hill, sword in hand. Flos smiled.

"Gazi."

The mounted archer lowered her bow when she saw Gazi's head appear over the hilltop. She didn't appear surprised to see her. And neither did she put away the arrow.

Gazi smiled widely, showing the woman her sharp teeth. She had her two-handed blade in her left hand, and all four of her eyes were fixed on the woman's face.

"Lady Maresar."

"Gazi. I should have known you were about."

"I follow my King. Just as you seem to follow your husband."

Maresar spoke shortly, with a slight lisp.

“He is a fool. But he will not die so long as I live.”

“And neither will you harm my King.”

Gazi spread her hands. Maresar nodded.

“So. We are at an impasse. I have my soldiers camped below this ridge.”

“I know.”

“Your big eye isn’t open. I could shoot you if I had to.”

“You won’t.”

Maresar turned her head. She was staring at Flos as he stood over Venith.

“And why is that?”

Gazi turned her head to stare at her King.

“My lord did not come here to kill. I know him. Your husband won’t die today.”

Lady Maresar stared at Gazi. For a second her hand tightened on her arrow, and Gazi’s hand tightened on her greatsword. Then Maresar smiled and lowered her bow.

“Very well. If you are wrong I will kill you first.”

Gazi just grinned in reply.

Trey stood with Teres, watching. That was what he seemed to do. Watch. Yet he was a part of this scene as well. He stood next to the King of Destruction, after all. He stood next to the King of Reim as, sword in hand, he stood over his former vassal.

Venith Crusland. The man had regained consciousness. He stared bitterly up at Flos.

“Finish it this time. Or I swear I will come back for your head again.”

Flos smiled.

“After all this time, you haven’t changed Venith. I told you once. I like you. You fought by my side for countless years. Shed blood in my name. I could never kill you.”

“But I could kill *you*. I swore an oath.”

Venith struggled to his feet, but fell back. He coughed and stared with hatred at Flos. Real, deep hatred. Trey could see that plainly, but he also saw how Venith’s eyes hadn’t left Flos’ face. They searched every inch of the King’s expression, as if looking for something.

“You betrayed us. You left us.”

Flos’ head bowed. He made no reply. Venith raised his voice. He shouted as the villagers fell silent, and his soldiers watched.

“You abandoned your kingdom! A King! Every army in the world came after us, cutting us down. I swore an oath to save my people, to protect them since you would not! I am bound to kill you or die trying.”

“A powerful oath.”

Flos nodded slowly. Venith bared his teeth.

“I have never broken my vows. You know that.”

“I do.”

“So.”

Venith struggled to lift a hand. He pointed to the blade in Flos’ hand.

“End it. Or we shall fight again. Again and again, until I am dead.”

Trey heard a choked sound from Calac. He was held tightly by two of Venith’s soldiers. Flos nodded.

“Your honor. Your vows. For your people you took them, and I know you are bound to fulfill them. However, I would say one thing to you, Venith Crusland.”

He raised the sword in his hands. Venith narrowed his eyes and gritted his teeth silently. Flos stared at Venith, and then tossed the sword at his feet.

“I do not care.”

Venith stared. Trey stared. Teres stared. The villagers and soldiers were statues. But Flos just smiled. And laughed. And then he shouted so everyone could hear.

“I am no petty tyrant, no fearful monarch! I am Flos, King of Destruction! My heart is large enough to suffer a thousand insults, but too small to accept the loss of one friend. I care not that you renounced your oath of service, Venith. I care not that you swore a vow against me. Join me, and we will fight together as before.”

He held a hand out to Venith. The man stared up at him, open-mouthed. Then he snarled and swiped at Flos’ hand.

“You *bastard*. You trampled over our dreams, abandoned us when we needed you most! And you dare to come back twenty years later, as if nothing has changed?”

“Yes.”

The man’s voice broke as he screamed at Flos, at his King.

“How dare you! How dare you—you trampled over us once. And now you come back as if nothing happened, spouting your same lies? How can you say the same thing again? You are a heartless tyrant, a fool!”

“*That is what it means to be a King.*”

Venith fell silent. Flos stared down at him.

“You are right. I cannot take back the past. I cannot undo my mistakes or erase my sins. And they are the gravest of this world. There is no one less deserving of a crown than I. And yet, I am your King. Your King, Venith. Just as you are my vassal.”

Flos moved slowly. He turned to face the crowd of people, the soldiers, the villagers, the twins. But when he spoke, it was only towards Venith.

“I care nothing for your oath. I care not that you raised your sword against me. I only care for you, Venith. I crave your company, more deeply than a lover, more urgently than a babe. I need you, Venith Crusland. Follow my back once more. Be my sword and shield and run with me one more time. One last time. We still have not reached the ends of the earth. But this time we shall.”

Venith stared up at Flos silently, eyes filled with an emotion Trey could not name. The King gazed down at him.

“My kingdom fell to dust because I was not ready before. But this time my dream is rekindled. And it is larger. This time it reaches beyond one continent. It encompasses the world. That is how far we will go. To the edge of the world and beyond. To the furthest nation, to the highest peak. Once, a young boy dreamed of making the world a better place. Now a grown man dreams of the same. The fire burns again in my chest, Venith. I see in my heart lands I have never laid eyes on, of oceans I have never crossed. And I know my enemies wait for me there, uncountable, and allies too. Waiting for the moment I dare to step forwards.”

He held his hand out, blood dripping between his fingers.

“The world waits for me. But I cannot face it alone. So I ask you once more. Renounce your oath. Take my hand or go. But know that you will always be mine. My sworn companion. My friend.”

All was hushed. Venith stared up at Flos’ bloodied hand. He stared at his King. And reached out.

“My King.”

Venith shook his King, grasped his hand. He stared into empty eyes, a vacant expression. Flos stared back, but there was nothing of him in there.

“It is over, Venith.”

“No!”

The man turned and glared at the one who had spoken. Gazi. She was standing next to the throne, eyes downcast, more defeated than he had ever known her. Standing to her right, a soldier, one of the Rustängmarder who would ferry orders to the rest of the company, stood at attention. He and Venith had heard the words from Flos’ mouth, but Venith couldn’t accept it.

“It’s not over!”

“It is. It is all over. I am finished.”

The words came slowly and at a distance from Flos’ mouth. He did not look at Venith. He sat slumped in the small chair, staring at the ground. But Venith refused to hear.

“We can still fight! Give me a command and I will lead your armies myself!”

“It’s not about armies.”

Flos didn’t raise his head. He stared down at his hands.

“She is dead, Venith. Queravia is dead. So is Tottenval.”

“What?”

Something cold lurched in Venith. He had known. But—

“We found his body today.”

Gazi spoke quietly. There were tears in her eyes. Venith couldn’t speak for a few moments. He felt his eyes sting, but he couldn’t stop.

“Even so. Even so—we have to continue. We owe it to them! You can’t just—”

His voice broke. It couldn’t be happening. It couldn’t all be over. The entire kingdom, gone. Not like this. Not—

“It is over, Venith. I am done. The King of Destruction is no more.”

“What about your people? What about your retainers, those who have sworn themselves to you?”

“I cannot be their King.”

Venith lost control. He struck Flos with all his might. The King’s head snapped back, but he didn’t look at Venith. He didn’t react to the blow. He just sat, staring ahead. Silent. That was worst of all.

It was more than Venith could stomach, more than he could bear to see. He would have struck his King once more, but someone caught his hand.

“Don’t do that again.”

Gazi stared at Venith, her grip a vice on his arm. Venith knew he could break her grip, but he saw the look in the half-Gazer’s eyes. And the

Rustängmarder soldier was staring at him. They tolerated no treason in their ranks. Another blow and it might be Venith's corpse lying on the ground.

After a moment, Gazi let go of Venith and he lowered his hand. He stared at his King. A shell. Just that. There was nothing left of his King here, just his appearance. Venith turned away.

"I will never accept it. I will not. I will wait! Until the day you come to your senses."

Flos made no reply as Venith strode out of the room, slamming the door behind him. And he waited. He waited until it was too late to go back.

Venith took Flos' hand. The King smiled. He pulled Venith up. The [Lord] stared at his King. Then he smiled.

And struck Flos in the face.

Trey cried out in shock. The King's head reeled back. He took a step as the people around him surged forwards, howling in fury. But Flos' hand held them back like a real thing.

"I have not forgotten the day you turned your back on me. My answer is no."

Flos nodded slowly. The King stared at Venith, not angrily, but with deep disappointment.

"Very well. Go. But know this, Venith Crusland. For two decades you protected my subjects. You guarded them against bandits and monsters alike and kept them fed. You built them a wall, and took care of my people. For that I owe you a debt beyond measuring. And yet."

He looked Venith in the eye.

"And yet, it was not enough. You gave them food, shelter, pride in honest work. But you could not give them *hope*. Your dream is still not grand enough. And that is why they will always be mine."

He turned away, and Venith stumbled, as if his strings were cut. In a moment his son and another soldier were by his side. They propped Venith up. He stared at Flos and then turned without another word.

Flos turned away as well. He walked slowly back towards Trey and Teres. He paused to look at them and then reached out.

“I am tired, you two.”

That was all he said. Then he walked back into the village, head bowed.

Venith rode away from Manimar, feeling every inch of his body hurt. He could barely sit in his saddle, but he sat with back straight when he saw who was waiting ahead of him.

“Mares.”

His wife, [Lady] Maresar smiled and rode to meet Venith. She eyed her husband’s face, and then looked at her son. She frowned at him, which made Calac flinch. Then she looked at Venith and raised an eyebrow.

“Are you feeling better now? That’s twice you’ve struck your own King.”

“He is no longer my King.”

Venith gritted his teeth. His hands were still numb, and he couldn’t feel a distinct part of his face. Maresar only shook her head.

“I heard him shouting from the hill. He is your King. He claimed you, despite how you greeted him. And still you think he hasn’t returned?”

He couldn’t properly reply to that. Venith tried to flex his hand.

“I swore an oath.”

“So you did. But you swore one to him first, if I recall.”

“He *abandoned*—”

Maresar silenced Venith with another look.

“I didn’t come here to argue the same thing again. You are wounded, dear husband. You had better have a [Healer] see to your injuries.”

He nodded grudgingly. Venith hesitated.

“I am...glad you decided to come after all. Despite our differences.”

“Hm.”

She smiled at him. Venith reached out, and she brushed his hand away. He frowned.

“What is it?”

“I brought half of our retainers with us. Don’t worry; there are enough hands back at home to keep everything working. Until you decide to forgive your King, you’ll have to make do with that.”

He heard her, but he didn’t want to understand.

“Mares, what are you saying?”

“He’s *my* King too, Venith. You might have thought about that when you decided to challenge him. I’ll wait by his side, but not for too long. Hurry up and make peace with the past already.”

She rode past him. Venith reached out for her but missed. He called out as his wife rode past.

“*Mares!*”

She didn’t look back once. Venith stared at his wife’s back as she rode away from him. He stared at his King. He clenched his fist and turned away.

Trey saw the procession of soldiers approaching with the woman archer at their head. Flos had seen them too. But he didn’t appear alarmed. He smiled and stopped the woman bandaging his hand.

He walked towards the woman with open arms. Trey saw a woman, darker skinned, hair cropped short, a bow at her back. She was smiling and

kicked her horse into a gallop. She leapt from the saddle and onto the ground before Flos.

And then she slapped him. The *crack* of flesh meeting flesh turned every head in range. Trey felt like he could feel his own cheek stinging as Maresar lowered her hand. Flos blinked at her. Then the woman, Lady Maresar, flung her arms around him and kissed his cheek.

“Ah, Maresar. I am overjoyed to see you haven’t changed.”

Flos laughed as he hugged her. Maresar embraced him tightly and then let go. She was actually taller than he was, although not nearly as heavy.

“That was for leaving us. And that was for coming back. I am delighted to see you, my lord.”

“And I you. But your husband hasn’t joined us.”

Maresar smiled a bit sadly.

“He still has not forgiven you. But you are my King. He will come back in time.”

“So I trust.”

Flos looked at the ranks of soldiers that spread out behind their [Lady]. Each man or woman slowly knelt.

“Those who would not march against you have come to fight for you.”

“I am honored.”

Flos turned to look at someone who came towards him, apart from the army.

“Gazi.”

Gazi the Omniscient smiled at her King. She had sheathed her sword, and was looking around at the people around her with all four eyes. Some had already recognized her, and the people calling her name sounded almost as exuberant as when they’d shouted for Flos.

“Lady Gazi!”

“Gazi the Omniscient has returned!”

“My lord.”

She stopped and bowed her head politely to Flos. He grinned at her.

“I should have known you would spot me going, even without your main eye.”

“Of course.”

“I suppose I should only be relieved that Orthenon and Mars didn’t notice and drag me back as well.”

Flos glanced towards the sky, where the sun was already rising. He grimaced.

“Then again, I’m sure they will have noticed by now. I don’t suppose you told them?”

“Orthenon would have found out soon enough. He’s coming with an army, by the way.”

Flos’ shoulders sagged.

“Really?”

Gazi only smiled and pointed south in reply.

Venith saw the army and the two riding at its head. He called an immediate halt to his men. They formed up, looking frightened.

Orthenon rode at the head of an army of mounted warriors. There were only around four hundred of them, all wearing mismatched armor, but they vastly outnumbered Venith’s force.

“Hold. They won’t attack.”

Or so Venith prayed. He spurred his horse towards Orthenon, wincing with every step his mount took.

“Lord Orthenon.”

He called out as the man approached. Orthenon did not immediately reply. He was holding a spear, two metal hafts sticking out just below the

shaft. He rode fast and hard at Venith, and the man slowed. Venith's hand grabbed his shield, as much out of reflex as conscious thought.

He wouldn't—

Orthenon raised his spear. Venith's arm moved up and he raised his shield overhead as his soldiers cried out.

The winged spear flashed down and crashed into Venith's raised shield. The impact *rang* throughout Venith's body and sent him tumbling off his saddle. Orthenon raised his spear and regarded the head, which had deformed from the impact. He tossed it to one side and Venith braced himself for the man to draw his sword. But Orthenon simply nodded calmly down at Venith as he lay on the ground.

“Lord Venith.”

He rode past the man as Venith struggled to his feet. Mars stared down at Venith and then rode past him without a word, sitting awkwardly on her mount. He was getting to his feet when she kicked him in the back.

Afterwards, Trey found he didn't know how they got back to Reim. There was only the procession of joyous people, singing and shouting Flos' name. He was riding with Flos in front as the King spoke to Maresar and Gazi, rubbing his cheek. And then there was the meeting with Orthenon and Mars.

The man rode towards Flos at a gallop, hundreds of mounted warriors following him. At a distance a huge scowl was visible on his face. It only grew larger as he got closer.

When he was in earshot, Orthenon began shouting.

“Do you have any idea how *recklessly* dangerous that was? I have [Scouts] and [Riders] searching in every direction still. We feared you were kidnapped. And you, Gazi! How could you not tell us where our King had gone? Do you have *any* idea what will happen after word of this spreads?

Where are we supposed to shelter these people? Their homes are *here*. How are we supposed to—”

“Orthenon.”

Flos interrupted his [Steward] calmly. Orthenon stopped, breathing hard. Flos half-turned in his saddle. He waved his arms at the cheering villagers, Maresar’s soldiers, and then expanded that wave to take in the army accompanying Orthenon. Flos nodded at it all.

“Take care of it.”

He paused, and then looked at Orthenon again.

“Please.”

He passed by the man and rode on. Trey could hear him calling out.

“Mars! Look who has decided to join us! Did you meet Venith on the road?”

He didn’t hear Mars’ shouted reply. Trey rode past Orthenon and saw the man staring at the mess behind Flos. And then...it was just for a second, but Trey could have sworn he saw Orthenon smile.

And at midday, when he was about to fall asleep, Trey found Flos. The King was sitting in his room, cheek no longer red, hand healed. He didn’t look as tired as Trey, but he was a bit less energetic in greeting the boy.

“Trey. Is there no Teres today?”

“No si—your ma—Flos. She’s asleep.”

“A wise decision. I would sleep, but Orthenon insists on keeping me awake.”

Flos glanced regretfully towards his bed. He shook his head and looked at Trey.

“But you have no [Steward]. Why are you awake?”

“I don’t know.”

Trey didn't know why he was bothering Flos, for all the King clearly enjoyed it. He hesitated.

"Is—is that Venith going to come back and try to kill you again?"

Flos raised his eyebrows, looking mildly surprised.

"Him? I doubt it. As Orthenon told me countless times, it was foolish to leave my city without an escort. Venith has not the men to challenge me if I go forth with proper protection. More to the point, Lady Maresar is now with me, and I doubt he would try to take up arms against his wife."

"But he did try to kill you."

"Yes. I suppose he did."

Flos stared at his hand, now free of blood. He smiled as he flexed it.

"But that is the thing about Venith. He has tried to kill me once before, did you know? When we first met. Yet he did it so poorly then, and so poorly now, I wonder if that was ever his intention."

"What do you mean?"

"He could have attacked with his soldiers. Or shot me from afar. Or simply alerted any number of my enemies that I was in Manimar alone and defenseless. I can think of a few enemies – the Emperor of Sands for one – who might use a teleportation spell to send an assassin after me without a second thought. But he did not. He challenged me to a duel."

"To test you?"

"Perhaps. Or perhaps because he had to be the one who struck me. I confess that I do not know. But I am glad to have heard his fury."

"Even though he hit you?"

"I deserve it, don't you agree? My face will not be marred by a single blow, although a few of Lady Maresar's slaps might do the trick."

Flos laughed. He stared pensively at the wall, his eyes going down to a blank spot on his dresser. Trey saw there was nothing there as well. No head. He wondered if Flos had buried it yet.

The King sighed.

“It is an odd thing, Trey. I went to Manimar unsure whether I would be forgiven for my failure. And yet now all I can dwell on is a single vassal of mine.”

He spread his hands as he sat on his bed, motioning Trey to join him. Trey did, almost too afraid to sit properly. Flos loomed above him, as big as the room itself. But tired. He only looked tired in here, nowhere else. And only when Trey and Teres could see him.

“I wronged him, Trey. I committed the gravest sin a [King] could make. He is right to be furious. If he never forgave me I could not speak a word of protest and be justified in it. And yet, I would give much to have him back.”

Trey cleared his throat awkwardly.

“I understand that.”

“You do? Good. Today was a victory, if there were winners or losers to be counted. But it is not the same, Trey. Not the same.”

“As what?”

Flos sighed.

“As before. Perhaps it was simply that I was young and did not see the cost in everything I did back then. But today my triumph is bittersweet.”

“I get that, too.”

“Really now? What is so lacking for you, Trey?”

“I—well, it’s nothing.”

Trey wished he hadn’t opened his mouth. But now Flos was staring at him, and Trey unwillingly continued.

“It’s just...today, well, yesterday I mean, Teres did a lot of good things. She yelled at you, threw that rock at Venith’s son when he tried to kill you —”

“Ah yes. She was brave.”

“Yeah.”

Trey nodded. He felt proud of his sister. But...

“But I didn’t do much, really.”

“Ah. Are you jealous of your sister?”

“No! Maybe. I’m not jealous. I just wish *I* could have done something useful too. But it’s always like this. Teres is always the braver one. She always does stuff first. I...don’t.”

He didn’t know why he was confiding in a King of all people. But there was something in the way Flos looked at him that told Trey he did understand.

“You know Trey, when I heard my subjects speaking in the dining hall, I was surprised to hear they considered both you and Teres worthless.”

It took Trey a minute to remember. It felt like an age ago.

“Well, we are, aren’t we?”

“Not so. You come from another world. From another *world*.”

“But we don’t know much. We don’t know how to make guns or how electricity is made or...anything.”

“And yet, it is the two of you who woke me from my slumber. Where all my vassals and time itself could not do so. What is that, if not worth?”

Flos placed a gentle hand on Trey’s shoulder. The young man looked up at him, and saw a smile.

“Shall I tell you something interesting, Trey? Something not even Gazi knows?”

“What?”

“When I was a young man, no one thought I would become anything special either. I was a low-level [Prince] of a tiny kingdom. My father had little time for me, and my subjects only thought of me as royalty, not someone to inspire them. Only my mother had faith I would be successful.”

“Really?”

“Truthfully, she was disappointed when I took up the sword. She always had hopes I would pursue other paths. Like poetry.”

“*Poetry?*”

“Oh yes. She thought I was a wonderful poet, despite my only ability being a small gift at rhyming. Let me see.”

Flos thought for a moment, and then spoke softly.

*“One last time let the forges roar.
Forevermore, forevermore.
Let hammers sing and bellows cry
And let voices split the very sky.
The King is awoke, the land awake
Now let us all an ending make.
So one last time the forges roar
And once all is over, nevermore.”*

Trey stared at him. Flos shrugged.

“It’s not good. But I could make such simple poems for my mother at will. It made her smile. The trouble is, such a talent is largely useless. I am a King who leads his people. What use is rhyming and pretty words as a talent? I failed my people. Would that I had a stronger spirit, they would have been better served. But now here I stand with sword in hand, the mark of my folly upon this land...”

He broke off, grimaced.

“You see? It is a terrible thing. And it comes upon me more the longer I think of it.”

Trey grinned and ducked his head. Flos smiled, and then stared pensively back at the wall.

“You may not see your worth, Trey. But I promise you, it is there. In you and Teres both. You two are not the same; it is folly to compare your actions, even for twins.”

“But we’re supposed to serve you. Shouldn’t we be...good enough?”

Flos laughed. It was a genuine sound, honest and pure.

“You woke me from my slumber, Trey. There is nothing more worthy in the world than that. And as for the rest...if you doubt yourself, keep following my back. Watch me, Trey. Come with me as I learn to be King again. And one day, you will be worthy of standing by my side.”

He clapped a hand on Trey’s shoulder and rose.

“Today was a start. I failed again, but I also succeeded. One village has come back to me. One small village, but it is part of me, Trey. This kingdom is my heart. Its people are my blood. Now it beats faster. Faster. Not with rage or sorrow, but excitement at last. I had awoken, but I did not remember what it was to be King. Now I am remembering.”

He stood, and strode towards the window. Trey followed him. Flos stared out across the empty landscape and smiled. Below him a city moved with people. It was still largely in ruins, still far emptier than it should be, but there was life down there. Growing.

“It is time to do what I should have done from the beginning. It is time to act, to lead them. Not as a man or memory. But as a [King].”

Flos smiled. He turned to Trey.

“Now, I believe I shall take a nap. If Orthenon comes looking for me, I’ll throw him out a window.”

And he grinned at Trey, looking like a young man wearing an adult’s face. And Trey looked into Flos’ eyes and laughed.

4.03 K

Two days after Flos returned to his city with an entire village at his back, Trey woke up at the crack of dawn. It was part of his new routine.

He woke up when Teres took his pillow away. That was a surefire method to waking Trey up. He opened his eyes grudgingly and saw she was already dressed and staring at a wall.

That was normal. Trey changed out of his clothes as Teres stood in place. They were used to giving each other privacy, but he suspected Teres wouldn't have looked around in any case. Sure enough, when he stumbled over to her, her eyes were closed and she was swaying in place.

"Teres."

"Go away."

"Gotta—"

"Nuh."

"Yeah."

He pushed her towards the door. Teres grudgingly moved rather than fall over.

This was their new day. And it was, to quote Teres, complete bollocks. Trey preferred outrageously bollocks, but the feeling was the same.

They had to get up at dawn, without eating brekkie, and head over to the training grounds.

People were already up and about at this time of day. But it did not make the twins any happier to see people walking about briskly, looking like fresh daisies. Trey would have loved to sleep in until at *least* seven or eight—Teres would prefer ten. But here they were.

"You're late."

For once, Orthenon did not receive the shy smile from Teres. She glared at him, which did not faze the steward in the slightest. He beckoned to Teres with a wooden sword in hand, and she stomped off after him.

“Trey! Excellent! Good to see you up!”

The booming voice reminded Trey of the time he and Teres had snuck some of their father’s alcohol into their room and tried it. The morning after had felt something like this. He winced and turned to bow towards Flos as the king strode towards him.

“Good morning.”

“I feel so as well. Come, Mars and I have been sparring lightly.”

The King threw an arm around Trey’s shoulders and half-dragged the young man towards Mars. As always Trey fought to keep his eyes on her face. There was always something eye-catching about Mars, but he was beginning to suspect at least part of the attraction he felt towards her was magical. It made sense, right? Mars wasn’t known as the Illusionist for no reason.

And as Teres had snidely pointed out, no warrior could get away without having any scars from battle. Flos had several on his arms, and Orthenon had a few. But Mars did not. Gazi didn’t either, actually, but Trey hadn’t bothered pointing that out to Teres.

“Trey. Ready to learn some more sword techniques?”

Mars greeted Trey cheerfully and he managed to nod without yawning. She laughed, tossed him a sword which he managed to catch this time – the last two days he’d dropped it – and they began training.

It was actually as dull as dull could be. Trey had expected practicing swordplay with the King of Destruction and one of the most high-level warriors in the world to be more exciting. But Mars and Flos just swung their swords in exaggeratedly slow motion, which looked easier than it was as well.

Trey tried to copy them, but he found that while he could deliberately swing his sword slowly the first eight times or so, his arms got really tired after the thirtieth swing. And his mind was extremely bored the entire time. By the time he was done, Trey was sweating and his arms hurt. But they weren’t done. Not even close.

After that, he hit a cloth dummy with his sword as Flos and Mars made him strike with proper footwork and form. Now Trey had to be quick and

precise, neither of which felt easy when he watched Flos hit his training dummy hard enough to make the wooden pole it was attached to *crack*. Faced with that example, every time Trey swung the sword he'd been given, he felt slow as an ox and weak as a baby.

"Alright, now it's practice time! Come on, hit me!"

Mars always said the same thing. She would grin and lift a shield up and rap on it with her practice sword. Trey would do his best to tap her with his sword, but she'd block him every time, often pausing to tell him why he'd failed to hit her as hard as possible.

It wasn't fun. When he was done for the day—a good hour later it felt—Trey was miserable. And his arms hurt. And his legs. He felt like his hands were getting blisters, and he just wanted to have something to *eat*.

"Ah, Trey. Don't look so depressed."

Flos jovially slapped Trey on the shoulder. Now Trey's shoulder hurt too. Trey glared up at the King of Destruction.

"I'm not good at fighting. Do I have to do it?"

"Unless you prove you can shoot lightning, or you find another class more suited to you, yes."

Flos smiled at Trey as Mars practiced against an invisible enemy with her sword and shield. She was always in the training grounds, even far later in the day. She often hung about, but she would train like that for hours on end.

Now she paused to look at Trey.

"You haven't gotten the [Warrior] class yet, have you Trey?"

Flos shook his head at the same time Trey did.

"I asked both Teres and Trey to refuse any classes for the moment. Until they were sure of their choice."

Mars' eyebrows rose.

"Refuse a class? You can do that?"

The King nodded. Trey had been so amazed to hear the voice in his head the first time he wouldn't have known to stop it unless he'd been told.

But Flos had told him that very night to do just that. The King frowned at Mars as he wiped some sweat from his brow.

“I could have sworn I told you about that, Mars.”

She shrugged, looking slightly guilty.

“I may have forgotten...”

Flos grinned.

“No matter. But I am not sure a [Warrior] is the class for Trey. Teres might find some success there.”

Trey looked around. Teres and Orthenon weren't in the courtyard. Apparently, Orthenon preferred other, less populated places to practice, and so every day Teres would leave with him and come back looking like she'd run a marathon.

“Why aren't I training with Orthenon? Is it because you think she'll be a better [Warrior] than I will?”

He didn't mean to sound hurt, but it must have come out, because Flos looked surprised as he turned towards Trey.

“Teres? Ah, well...yes.”

He blinked as Trey sagged.

“Surely you noticed, Trey? Teres is a bit more instinctual when it comes to fighting than you are. I recall seeing it the first time I sparred with you. She tried to stab me several times. Quite viciously, too.”

“So she's got talent?”

Mars shrugged.

“Yeah.”

The combination of Flos and Mars was destroying what little ego Trey had. But Flos shook his head slightly as the young man sighed and lowered his head.

“It isn't skill in my eyes so much as attitude. She takes to battle with a passion. You think more, Trey, which is why I decided to split you two up.”

“But why? Is Orthenon a better swordsman or something?”

The King and Mars paused. They shared a glance. To Trey's immense surprise Flos nodded.

"Probably?"

"No he's not."

Mars scowled and folded her arms. Flos smiled at Trey conspiratorially.

"In truth, Orthenon isn't a match for Mars. But his skill with a sword is—different from ours. He learned his style from a foreigner, and as such, doesn't fight in a way that Mars or I could emulate. We learned how to fight on the battlefield and from experienced warriors. But Orthenon *studied*."

"Oh."

"He's not better than me."

Mars kicked at the dirt, looking stubborn and petulant. Flos sighed.

"But it is not his main class, so he is not comparable to someone like Mars whose Skills are all geared towards combat. I thought Teres would be a good pupil for him for other reasons, though. His temperament and hers are quite similar."

"No."

Trey shook his head instantly. He couldn't imagine Orthenon, always calm, always polite and thoughtful, being anything like his sister. Teres could be all those things, but she got *mad*. But to his great surprise, Mars was nodding along with Flos.

"Orthenon? He's got a temper alright."

"No. You're taking the Mickey out of me!"

"I am being quite serious, Trey. I have never known Orthenon to ever unsheathe his sword without a bit of wrath. I have seen him lose his temper on the battlefield, and it is a sight to see."

"He gets really mad, Trey. Did you see what happened when he met Venith? He knocked him straight off of his horse with one blow!"

Mars laughed as she recounted the tale to Flos and Trey. Flos nodded.

"But he controls his temper. Well, usually. Orthenon wields his anger just as keenly as he does a blade. If he can teach that to Teres, she will

benefit greatly. Or so I feel.”

Trey could just shake his head at this new revelation. He felt like he learned something new about the people around him every day. Mars slung an arm around Trey’s shoulder and laughed when he blushed.

“Don’t be too upset though, Trey! Orthenon’s not fun to practice with at all. And he’s strict! You’ll have a lot more fun with our King and me.”

“Exactly!”

Flos grinned at Trey. He and Mars laughed as they began talking about having Trey join them on morning runs around the walls, a pair of exercising loons. But Trey was stewing on what Flos had said, or rather, wasn’t saying. The King turned to Trey, smiling.

“I realize you may wish to join your sister, but she is taking the path I feel most suited towards her, and you will do best with Mars and I instructing.”

Trey stared at him and a piece fell into place in his mind.

“And you want to separate us up, is that it? You don’t want us to be together all of the time.”

Flos blinked. And then he burst out laughing as Mars stared at Trey with a look of surprise. Flos turned to her, smiling jovially.

“There, you see, Mars? Trey has seen the truth. He and Teres are valuable to me, I tell you. More valuable than you or anyone else knows.”

“I didn’t think he’d figure it out.”

Mars grinned as she eyed Trey. He felt a bit nonplussed. But Flos was nodding.

“You are right, Trey. I wished you and Teres to be apart from each other more.”

He looked at Mars, growing more serious as he gestured at Trey.

“The twins truly are a gift in my eyes. Teres speaks the truth to me. She is unafraid to point out my failures, to stand up to me in my moments of wrath and folly. But Trey is different. Trey understands how I think at times. He sees into my heart. And that is a gift worth far more than gold.”

And that was something else. When Flos said something, he meant it completely. Mars smiled at Trey as the young man turned red and tried to deny something. But then Teres came back, looking like road kill, and Orthenon joined Flos and Mars and asked what was so funny.

And the worst part was, Flos recounted the entire moment to Orthenon *and* Gazi with pride over breakfast. And he didn't lower his voice, so all the servants soon heard Trey's amazingly not-amazing bit of deduction.

In truth, Trey understood what Flos meant. He remembered the conversation they'd had, and the little secret of Flos' poetry that apparently not even Gazi knew about. Sometimes he felt like he understood Flos, as strange as that might be.

At other times, the King was as distant and unexplainable as the stars. Like when he decided the policy of the realm. But he did try to explain himself.

After going to Manimar, Flos had changed his daily routine. He no longer strode about the castle inspecting every little detail of his kingdom. Rather, he left most of that to Orthenon, allowing the steward to inform him of notable events. Directly after breakfast he would retire to his throne room, where he would consult with his trusted vassals.

Among that number was now Lady Maresar. Regardless of whether she was present at breakfast, she would come striding into the throne room at the same time Gazi appeared, to stand before their King and listen and speak to him.

She was tall, dark, and more handsome than beautiful, but Teres had punched Trey in the side for making that joke. Lady Maresar didn't scare Trey exactly, but she was hard to read. She didn't speak much in her slightly slurred, deep voice, like Gazi. But when she *did* speak it turned out she had a sense of humor.

"It is good you sit on your throne, my King. Else we would have had to kick you off the chair you sat on yesterday."

That had been the debate of yesterday, which had lasted two hours. Flos sat on his throne, looking down at Trey, Teres, Orthenon, Mars, Gazi and Maresar. He wore no crown, but he sat on the throne as if he belonged there.

He was a different person on that throne. Flos' lips quirked upwards in a smile at Maresar's words, but he did not laugh uproariously as usual. He nodded down at her.

"Your words struck a chord in my heart, Maresar. I dislike going back on my words, even those uttered in passion, but it seems many of my vassals will be weeks or months in returning to me. If at all."

His vassals shifted at that. Orthenon crossed his arms, scowling. Gazi kept smiling. Mars scuffed at the ground with an armored foot. And Maresar nodded.

"My husband will return, my King. But he will take time, like the others. They must see that you are back not just in body, but spirit."

"True. And I rather disliked that chair."

Flos smiled quietly. Then he turned his attention to Orthenon.

"My steward. Inform me. What news?"

"Three more villages from Lord Venith's lands have declared their support for you, my lord. They are travelling towards the city, carrying all they can carry. Two more in adjacent provinces have sent messengers to see you. Word is spreading like wildfire, although it appears the local [Rulers] are attempting to halt any rumors of your return."

Flos leaned forwards on his throne.

"Have we space for these villagers? And how dangerous are the roads they travel on? I had heard word of [Brigands] and [Bandits] infesting the realms around my kingdom. They must be wiped out, saving Lady Maresar of course."

He nodded at her. Maresar nodded back. Trey stared at her and scratched his head. Orthenon shook his head calmly.

"I have already dispatched a group of [Riders] to ensure they arrive safely. As for [Bandits], none have ever dared venture too close to the city. Unless you have information I do not, Lady Maresar?"

She shook her head as all eyes turned towards her.

"I have not talked with many, but I do not think the most daring [Bandit Lord] would dare approach your kingdom. They still remember what

happened to the ones that Gazi hunted down.”

“Do you think she was a [Bandit], Trey?”

Teres whispered to Trey as the others talked about where to put the villagers in the meantime. He opened his mouth, but Maresar turned her head towards them. Orthenon broke off as she nodded to the twins.

“I was a [Bandit Lord] of renown before I was defeated and pledged my service to his majesty.”

“A bandit...lord?”

Trey stared at her. Mars grinned and laughed.

“Everyone thought Maresar was a lord, because they never saw her! That’s how she got the class, isn’t that right?”

Maresar looked disapprovingly over at Mars and shook her head.

“No. There is no [Bandit Lady] class. That is all. All leaders are known as [Bandit Lords], regardless of gender.”

“Oh.”

Mars scratched her head and blushed a bit. Flos cleared his throat and all eyes turned back towards him. He didn’t seem to mind the interruption, although Teres and Trey’s ears were red.

“What of the other cities and larger towns, Orthenon? If any would join me now, I would rest easier with their stores of grain and food added to ours.”

“Not to mention additional soldiers.”

Gazi nodded in agreement. Orthenon sighed, looking visibly annoyed.

“I have sent messengers to the cities of Rast, Belevadim, and Chalm bearing word of your return. I have yet to hear a response from any city.”

“No doubt they are considering their response. Which means their rulers deny me, or the citizens do as well.”

Flos shook his head.

“No matter. For now, continue training and drilling those who have chosen to fight. We have the makings of a decent army here, but I take it

you still lack the numbers you desire, Orthenon?”

The steward nodded.

“I have a good number of veterans, some quite old. I have given them the arms that Lady Mars obtained and they will act as a strong elite force. However, the plain truth is that we lack the proper numbers for a true army, and our newest recruits are of very low level.”

“The latter problem will be solved by the first battle. As for the first... well, I shall rely on the efforts of you four to overcome any difference in numbers.”

His vassals straightened and nodded. Flos pondered for a moment and then turned to Maresar.

“Maresar, would you take those you deem fit and train with them exclusively? I would like you to lead the archers in my army. I realize that was not your role before, but in the absence of any other warriors of note, I ask it of you.”

“I would be honored, my King.”

“Very well. Mars, if you will train with the newest soldiers and if both Gazi and Maresar will assist Orthenon in drilling the army to fight as one...”

They nodded at him. Flos turned his attention to Trey and Teres.

“Orthenon does not have the time to exclusively attend to the army. Lady Maresar and Gazi have both commanded units of soldiers and small armies of their own and know what is needed. Do you understand why we must train this army, despite having veterans of countless wars?”

It was far worse than being called on by the teacher in class. Far worse. Tongue-tied, both twins shook their heads. Flos nodded, not disappointed by their honesty.

“An army must fight as one. They must learn to follow commands given out by [Strategists] or [Tacticians] as a whole, which each smaller unit of soldiers must obey. A simple command like advance or retreat requires drilling, and the most elite armies are capable of maneuvers that can change the entire battlefield.”

“I understand.”

Trey nodded. He glanced at Mars.

“Um—why wouldn’t Lady Mars train the soldiers?”

She was a [Vanguard], which was an advanced type of the [Soldier] class, Trey knew. Flos hesitated while Mars herself flushed red.

“Mars is...not suited towards leadership, Trey. She is a [Soldier], yes, but one who fights, rather than takes up the mantle of a leader.”

The other vassals shifted and didn’t quite look at Mars. Trey felt incredibly guilty, but Flos simply nodded as if he’d asked an important question.

“Each one of my vassals stands out in their own way. Mars will teach the newest soldiers, those who have never held a sword before in their life, how to fight. That is what is needed. Now, I believe there is nothing left to discuss. If Orthenon receives a reply from any of the cities, we shall meet again. Until then, I shall attend to my daily lessons with Teres and Trey.”

The audience was over. Orthenon left at speed after bowing to Flos. Gazi vanished quickly as well, and Maresar and Mars both headed towards the training grounds. And Flos stood up from his throne and smiled. Teres and Trey exchanged a glance, and they came to the oddest part of their daily routine.

Teaching Flos. Story time with the King of Destruction. Flos’ school hour. No matter how Trey said it in his head, it didn’t feel any less surreal.

But it happened. Every day. Flos would walk to his room with the twins in tow, and they would sit in his personal quarters, on the padded seats that had been placed in the room, in front of a gilded table adorned with snacks and cool drinks, and tell him about their world.

Flos settled into his chair with a sigh. He took the snack of the day from a silver platter in front of him and eyed it curiously.

“What is this I have to sample today, Teres, Trey?”

“Yorkshire pudding, I think.”

It wasn’t quite like the good stuff back home, but Trey had to admit the [Cooks] had done a pretty good job of imitating the food from a description

alone. Flos listened with appreciation as Teres explained what Yorkshire pudding was, and how you ate it. With beef drippings and gravy.

“Ah, I see we have some provided for us.”

Flos reached for a gold-and-porcelain gravy boat. Trey and Teres exchanged another look. It was surreal to eat the food of their home on plates meant for royalty. But that was Flos. He wanted to try every food from their home, and so every day the kitchen staff would try to create something from Earth with mixed results.

“Mm. Far better than that black pudding that was served yesterday.”

Flos chewed down three Yorkshire puddings with delight while Trey and Teres shared one. They’d just had breakfast after all. Then Flos leaned back, a cup of mulled wine in his hands, and a Yorkshire pudding in the other.

“Now, on to the most delightful moment of my day. We had talked yesterday of your world. I understand the geography, although I can scarcely comprehend that every part of your world—a round world, no less!—is mapped. I thought long about what you had told me about the nature of planets last night. Is it perhaps that the edge of the world is linked by magic to the other edge of your world?”

Teres groaned and Trey shook his head as Flos stared at them expectantly.

“No, we told you, there’s no magic in our world!”

“That you know of.”

“Yes! And we know a lot!”

“Hmm. But then, your world truly is round, and there is no edge? No... place where the ocean ends?”

“No!”

Flos shook his head in amazement as the twins shook their heads in exasperation. He had the worst hangup about some things. Flos readily and ecstatically accepted the idea that the moon and the stars were other planets, far, far away. He was completely happy to listen to the twins tell him that lightning could be harnessed, steam could be turned into an engine, and oil

could be made into a fuel that allowed men to fly in metal birds through the sky.

It was almost incredible how easily he accepted such things, actually. But there was one thing Flos couldn't understand.

"Yet you say your laws apply to every planet. Each one is...round."

"Yes, Flos. But it doesn't *feel* round. You can walk across the entire world, or sail, and you'd never feel it getting curved. It would feel flat, but you'd be able to go the whole way around because it's round, you see?"

Teres took over for Trey while he sipped some water, preparing his throat for a lot of speaking. Flos scratched his head.

"I believe I understand. And yet, that is not true of this world."

"It is!"

Exasperated, Teres' sister glared at Flos.

"I know this world is big, but if you took a ship—look, you could calculate the earth is round by looking at the sun and shadows! People in Greece did it thousands of years ago!"

"I have no doubt you are telling me the truth. But this world is not round."

"How do you—"

"There is an edge of the world. A place where the sea ends."

Flos held up a hand to forestall Teres. She broke off, staring. Flos frowned.

"I have never seen it. But there have been mighty [Captains] and fearless [Sailors] and [Travellers] who have attempted to find the edge of the known world, Teres. If the world was round they would have come around the other side and said so, yes? But they do not. Out of every thousand ships that has dared to travel to the edge of the world, past Baleros, past Rhir, only one or two ever comes back."

"Really?"

Flos nodded, meeting Trey's gaze somberly.

“Yes. They come back screaming of a blackness which the water pours into, a place where light does not exist. The end of the world. So you tell me the world is round in your world, and I believe you. But what is true in your world is not true here.”

The twins stared at the King and felt the ground beneath them shift. A world with an end to it. Trey sat up in his chair, heart racing at the thought.

“How—how many people have seen the edge of the world? I mean, really?”

“In this lifetime? I doubt you would find more than one or two alive, if any. But those who have come back have been written of, and I have read many books which say the same. And the [Sailors] have their own tales. They believe it. As do the islanders.”

“Islanders?”

“I told you of them, did I not? They live on an archipelago, closest to that end of the world. The next time Orthenon shows you his maps, ask him to point it out to you. They know not to sail too far in one direction, lest they vanish forever. And—there are stories that sometimes something comes *up* from that place. Things that kill all they encounter and die slowly, if at all.”

There was suddenly a bit less warmth in the room. Trey shivered. He unconsciously reached out and Teres gripped his hand and squeezed it tightly.

“I have never been to the islands, so I do not know if those rumors are true. If I ever meet an islander that is not trying to kill me, I will ask. For now, let us speak of more pleasant things.”

Flos shook his head, and the dark atmosphere dissipated. He looked at the twins, and now there was excitement in his eyes.

“I asked you about the history of your nations yesterday. But do you recall what I wished to speak of today? Heroes. Tell me of your heroes and leaders, those who shook your world.”

“Okay? Um—anyone in particular?”

“The most famous ones. The bravest, the strongest—and the ones which exist only in legend.”

“What, you mean like stories? Like Hercules and—Superman?”

“Super...man?”

Flos leaned forwards, scooting his chair forwards, suddenly filled with excitement.

“There is a hero known as a Superman? Tell me about him first.”

“No—he’s a superhero. Not a real person!”

Teres held up her hands. Flos stared at her, eyes shining.

“A superhero? What is that?”

That was how Trey and Teres found themselves eating Yorkshire pudding in a palace, sitting with a [King] and telling him about Superman. Flos sat forwards, forgetting to eat or drink as he listened, enraptured, to stories about their world. He was like a child in that he demanded to hear stories of Earth, everything from the food Trey and Teres had eaten, to things like the shows they watched on telly, and what a telly actually was.

Flos was in love with the idea of comic books, of TV shows and video games when he got his head around the idea of them. He was a boy listening to tales of another world when he sat with Teres and Trey. But he was not like a child in how he reacted.

As it turned out, Flos was not interested in Superman at all, but found the idea of Batman intriguing, and Spiderman fascinating. He kept asking questions about him, and Teres, who’d read a few comics while browsing bookshops, struggled to answer properly.

“And you say these heroes exist in another world, made up in the minds of the people?”

“No. Yes! It’s a story. But there’s movies about them, books, comic books, video games, songs...”

“Songs? Sing one for me.”

“No!”

“Why not?”

“It’s *embarrassing*. Trey, you do it.”

“Why me? You do it, Teres!”

Embarrassment over singing the Spiderman song aside, Teres found that Flos was soon bored of superheroes. When he heard that most, if not all of them had died at one point and come back to life, Flos just shook his head and asked to hear about real heroes. So they told him about the people that had conquered entire nations when they lived.

To his surprise, Trey found that Flos was not interested at all in Alexander the Great. Privately, the boy thought Flos and Alexander sounded very similar, but Flos did not enjoy the comparison.

“A [King] who failed to fulfill his dream? He wished to see the sea, did he not? And he failed? What good is his dream then? No—what sort of [King] would fail his subjects so? They shared his dream, won him victories and carried him across countless lands. But he failed them. No, I do not wish to hear of a failure such as that.”

Flos paused, and laughed shortly.

“He is too much like myself, I fear.”

The same went for King Arthur, strangely. Even though he probably hadn't existed, he was a point of pride for Teres and Trey, that their country had claim to one of the real heroes of legend. Yet the King of Britannia pulled little weight in Flos' books. He just muttered to himself about arrogant [Mages] when he heard about Merlin, and had to be convinced that King Arthur wasn't just a pawn of fate. He wasn't impressed with the act of drawing a sword out of a stone, either.

“I can do that too. What measure of a King is this?”

Trey exchanged a glance with Teres. He had no doubt Flos could actually pull a sword out of a stone, but he was at a loss as to how to explain the difference. Flos just shook his head dismissively. He looked at Trey.

“A real leader this time. Please.”

“Okay. What about...Genghis Khan?”

“Ah. That is a worthy name. Tell me of him. Or her?”

Trey had to do almost all the explaining this time. Teres didn't remember much, so Trey had to wrack his brain for any details. Of the twins, Trey knew more about history than Teres and it was he who spoke up

more when it came to people who had actually existed, rather than mythical people.

“I have fought mounted raiders like these Mongols as you describe them. It is not a pleasant experience. I could well imagine them conquering a vast portion of the world if not checked.”

Flos nodded. He looked at Trey and Teres, impressed for some reason.

“You two are well versed in the stories and history of your world. Tell me, were you scholars? How did you come to know so many tales?”

Teres shrugged.

“Our da told us a lot of stories when he’d get home from work. When he did, he’d talk with us until he fell asleep in his chair.”

She smiled and Trey grinned at her, as they remembered those happy moments. Then the smile vanished; they remembered they hadn’t seen their father in over a month. Flos cleared his throat and the twins looked at him. But he didn’t change the subject.

“I regret that I have not met him. Perhaps one day I shall. Tell me about him, if you would.”

So they did. Their father wasn’t an exciting man to them; he was a good father, but he had a steady job, a slightly boring one. Teres flushed a bit when she told Flos he was a train guard who travelled a lot and seldom came home. Trey looked down moodily and Flos noticed.

“A working job is a fine one. What is there to be ashamed of?”

Teres bit her lip. Trey tried to explain. It wasn’t that being a train guard wasn’t bad—it just wasn’t being a conductor, or a train driver. It wasn’t the worst paying job, but it was the kind of thing you could get into fights over if you went to a nice school where some kids had parents with ‘better’ jobs.

“Ah. I see.”

Flos pondered, and then shook his head.

“Actually, I fail to. I can imagine such squabbles being similar to those I have seen in courts, where the daughters and sons of the lesser aristocracy squabble with those of a higher rank...but I have not experienced that directly myself.”

Trey bit his lip, remembering he *was* speaking to a [King]. Flos frowned as he bit into his pudding.

“I must confess, I understand little about money. But your father works hard, does he not?”

“Yes!”

“Then he is worthy of praise. That is all I understand, and all I care to. Those who work hard should be rewarded, regardless of station.”

The twins fell silent at that. There was a dismissive tone in Flos’ voice. Not dismissive in a bad way. Just a fact. *The world is the way I say it is, and so I am right.*

“I note that Trey seems to know more of such figures than you, Teres. Why is that?”

“I like school and studying. That’s all.”

Trey hunched his shoulders a bit guiltily, but Flos nodded.

“What is there not to like? A place where the young may learn free of danger, in their own time. I have not encountered such a system in this world, nor thought to implement one myself. There are academies, institutions where the gifted may learn. Some to become [Tacticians], or [Knights] who serve first as [Squires]...and of course there is Wistram which trains mages and other mage schools. But never a place where all may learn, free of charge. Where all must learn. It has a certain attraction to it.”

He paused, frowned, and then sighed, suddenly dispirited.

“And yet, these ‘schools’ are dangerous in and of themselves. If being a student is a class—and you seem to describe it as such, I fear I must not allow any schools to be created. At least, not as they exist in your world.”

“What? Why?”

They looked at him, surprised. Flos hesitated. He looked around the room, oddly, as if he expected someone to be listening. But Flos had banned servants from entering when they’d glared at Trey and Teres for calling Flos by his name. He looked at Trey and Teres and seemed to come to a decision after a moment of thought.

“I am a [King]. I have lived many years, and come to understand the way in which leveling works. I know secrets, Trey, Teres, of the true nature of classes and Skills. Other rulers lack my knowledge, simply because they have never reached the level I possess. I shall share one insight with you, but you must keep it secret.”

They nodded, fascinated. Flos took a breath and glanced at the door. Then he leaned forwards and whispered to the twins.

“The more classes one has, the weaker they become. Or should I say—the weaker they will become over time? What I mean is, a person with a single class will always reach a higher level than one with many classes.”

They stared at him. Teres coughed.

“No kidding?”

The King of Destruction looked bemused.

“That is an important secret! It is a secret of rulers, and why they forbid their offspring to take up common classes.”

“Yeah. That makes sense.”

Their cavalier response seemed to irk Flos. In truth, it made sense to Trey. He’d played videogames. He knew how such systems worked. But this was some grand piece of knowledge in this world, apparently. Flos frowned as he bit his lip.

“I admit, it is not an earthshattering secret. But what about this one? Some classes are simply better than others.”

He paused and frowned.

“No, again, perhaps better is not the right word. I can understand what I mean in my head, but out loud I struggle to explain. Let me try again.”

Flos thought for a moment and then nodded.

“Many classes are specific to one need. A [Farmer] grows crops and manages his land and his livestock. A [Weaver] creates things made of thread; a [Blacksmith] works with iron. They can expand their skillset, but a [Farmer] will never acquire skills to aid in dancing. He may well gain a Skill that allows him to defend his land in combat, or one that allows him to

lead others that he might expand his helpers, or one that helps him heal injured people or animals. But he is still locked into his path, you see?”

The twins nodded. That was straightforward. Flos dipped his half-eaten Yorkshire pudding in the gravy again, which made them both stare at him. He ate it down, ignoring their looks.

“But some classes have more...opportunity. And more force in them. A [Survivor] has many Skills, but a [Lord] will have more powerful Skills, although he may take Skills from many walks of life. And a [King] stands above all other classes, one of the few that has the strongest Skills, the most powerful benefits. There are other classes, and other combinations of classes that have strength too. But if you aim to reach the highest level possible, you must know what it is you search for, not squander your strength. That is why I have prevented you from taking useless classes like [Servant] or [Warrior] without knowing what you will become. Do you understand?”

“Yes. Does this mean you know of some...combined classes?”

“A few. But I would not necessarily steer you towards such classes. In the end, you must still find what suits you. It will become obvious in time. But enough of my world. Back to yours.”

He looked expectantly at Trey. The young man scratched his head. Teres nudged him.

“What about Churchill?”

“Oh! Right!”

They had told Flos about World War II in the broadest of terms, but he was fascinated to hear the role that Britain had played back then. However, Flos was less enamored of the great Winston Churchill, for a reason that seemed petty to Trey and Teres.

“You think his joke is bad? It’s just a comeback! ‘*You are ugly, tomorrow I shall be sober and you will still be ugly.*’ That’s not nice, but it is funny!”

Flos shook his head, crossing his arms adamantly as Teres argued with him.

“A ruler should not speak so to his subjects, or to anyone else for that matter. Humorous it may be, but a common insult is just that. Common.”

Thereafter he completely lost interest in any more tales about Churchill, much to the twin’s private indignation.

“I have heard of great leaders, but these are your people, are they not? Tell me of your greatest enemies, those who made your nation shudder in fear. I would know of them too.”

That was a loaded question, and though one person immediately sprang into Teres’ mind, Trey had another thought. Perhaps it was inevitable that Trey thought of Gandhi. Because he was everything Flos was not.

And he *fascinated* the King of Destruction.

The instant Trey began telling Flos about Gandhi and what he had done—taking his home country of India back from British rule with nonviolence, with peaceful protest and the idea of passive resistance, Flos had to stand up and pace about the room. He couldn’t contain his excitement.

“That is a far better tale than any you have told me thus far. Gandhi. A name to inspire. You say he took a country, a *nation* without a single death? And it happened? Truly?”

Trey hesitated. Teres stared at him and they shared the same thought.

“Not exactly. I know some people died—that was when Gandhi fasted. He refused to do anything and starved himself unless people were nonviolent.”

“And they did. He held his life over the heads of his people. Magnificent.”

Flos shook his head, eyes alight with wonder.

“There were deaths. I understand. It is a consequence of leading that not all obey. But still. To do such a thing—”

He broke off. Flos had to pace around the room in his excitement.

“I am moved. I am in awe. I would like to see if I might do the same. To do what he did. But...no. Perhaps it is not the time. This British empire, your land’s rulers...they gave in because they cared that they did wrong. I

regret to say that if this Mahatma Gandhi were to appear before me, he would not succeed in his quest.”

He drooped. Trey and Teres stared at him.

“What? What do you mean?”

Flos shrugged.

“Were such a man, a [Pacifist] or...no, his very name is the class, is it not? A [Mahatma]. If such a one were to appear before me, well...I would like to imagine that my people would never be so dissatisfied with my rule as to rise up. If such a person appeared before me, I believe I would be able to find some common ground. But if not, if words failed and such an opponent were to send my kingdom into turmoil, I would remove him.”

Chilling words. Trey could barely bring himself to ask.

“How?”

Flos did not immediately answer.

“There are many ways to stop such a man. I could lock him away, not for years or decades, but forever. I could send him to a far continent. Kill him? No. I would not do that. But the problem with this brave soul is that he can only exist in your world. In a place where empires and nations care for notions like morality. Were he to come here, most [Kings] would execute him on the spot. And I...would not let his rebellion pass either.”

Trey felt a shiver run down his spine. There was a grim, sad look on Flos’ face. He remembered something he’d heard once, something that had been said of Gandhi. Even he would not have known how to stop Hitler. Or was it that even he would have failed? Trey couldn’t remember what he had been told, but the thought bothered him greatly.

Flos noticed. He always seemed to notice when Trey bit his lip, or shifted.

“What have you thought of, Trey?”

The boy coughed.

“N-nothing.”

“Ah. You do not wish to tell me. Which must mean what you are concealing is important indeed. Speak...please.”

For a little while Trey resisted. But then he told Flos.

“So I remind you of a man named Hitler in some ways, do I? Who was he?”

Teres looked at Trey. He nodded, and she took a breath and looked Flos right in the eye.

“He was probably the most vile, evil man who ever lived.”

He didn't react to the implication. He only nodded, and settled back in his chair. He was no longer smiling. Now he was listening intently.

“All the more reason to tell me, then. What did he do?”

They told him about World War II. They told him about Hitler, about Nazis, and what had started it all, the Third Reich and its consequences. Flos listened silently, unmoved by all of it. He had seen worse. But he shifted when they told him about what had happened to the Jews. And when they talked of the worst of it, the concentration camps, the gas chambers, and the rest, he grew very still.

When it was over, they waited for him to speak. Flos' head was bowed, and when he raised it, there were tears in his eyes. But he said only one thing that made Trey very afraid.

“From what you have said, I must call this man Hitler a great leader.”

He held up a hand as Teres leapt to her feet.

“Listen. A great leader, and a poor thing not worthy to be called a man. That is what he was.”

Slowly, Teres sat down. Flos stood up, and turned his back to stare out of the window.

“Hitler. There is a name that rings throughout your world. Understand me, Teres, Trey. Yes, I admire this man Hitler as a leader. I reject his ideals, his beliefs, and the empire he created and the things he did. But he commanded the hearts of a nation and forged a defeated people into a blade that sought the throat of the world. He created darkness I had not dreamt of. He tried to kill an entire people. How can such a man not be worthy of

praise, damning though it may be? And yet. He was no [King]. And he was not worthy of such a title.”

He left it at that. Slowly, the conversation moved to other things. Flos was nearly in tears when the conversation went back to Gandhi, and they told him how he had died, assassinated in cold blood.

“These guns of yours...you speak of them and I find myself less enamored with the thought of them with each passing moment. One slew a man of peace, Gandhi. They are no proper weapon. They have brought low your world.”

It was hard to argue against that, though Teres did try, if only to explain to Flos how dangerous guns were compared to swords. But he was against them with all his heart.

“If any leader can be killed by a fool with a second of training, how can your world have heroes? How can people look up to those who would inspire them, when they are as vulnerable as the next person to a weapon which kills in an instant? How can children sleep safe at night, when they know their lives may be snatched away in a second?”

“You could do that with a sword!”

“But a sword does not reach out and kill people. Arrows do that, but a child cannot hide a bow and use it in a moment. I cannot hide a crossbow so easily. And in this world, a fool cannot so easily snuff out hope in a single moment.”

He looked away from Teres, who had no reply, and at Trey.

“The world must have heroes, Trey. It must have leaders, and men and women to shake the hearts of many. Guns are a foolish thing. I am only grateful that they might be overcome if they were to spread to my world.”

“How?”

It was inconceivable for Trey to imagine knights or men with swords trying to fight an army with machine guns. But Flos seemed confident, even dismissive.

“I can think of two ways I might easily defeat an army armed with... guns.”

His nonchalance enraged Teres.

“What about a battalion of tanks and fighter jets? Or a nuke?”

They had to explain again what all three things were to Flos. But when he understood, he just shook his head.

“There are ways. If your world has no magic, these weapons are fearsome, but not insurmountable. Such an army could slay a thousand conventional armies, I will admit, but I wonder how Amerys would do against such a force. If it came to it, I could devise a method to catch a ‘jet’ capable of flying through the air ten times faster than Takhatres. The same goes for the armor of your tanks, or defeating these bullets.”

He would not elaborate in detail, no matter how the twins pestered him.

“This world will not bow so easily if yours seeks to challenge us. I promise you that. But enough. If it comes to it, I shall see the terrible weapons of your world with my own two eyes. In the meantime, I have indulged my interests too long. Thank you for talking with me, Teres, Trey. Now, it is time to talk to Orthenon. Alas.”

They jumped in surprise, because a moment after Flos said that, someone rapped urgently on the door.

“Enter.”

A servant appeared, with a request to meet Orthenon in the throne room at once. A reply had come from one of the cities. Flos was out the door and striding down the corridor before Trey and Teres could hurry after him. Trey grabbed a handful of Yorkshire puddings as he left.

When they got to the throne room, Flos was already seated on his throne. Nervously, the twins edged into the room, but the others greeted them warmly. Orthenon blinked at the Yorkshire pudding Teres offered him, but he took it readily enough.

“What news, my steward?”

Flos regally dipped a Yorkshire pudding into the gravy that a servant had brought. Mars was already chewing down her third pudding as Orthenon straightened and spoke.

“They have denied your return, my King.”

“As expected.”

Flos sighed. But Orthenon wasn't done.

“That is the official response. The messenger I sent was not allowed anywhere in the city, no doubt to prevent rumors spreading. And she was escorted a good distance away from the city before being released. However, she encountered a [Trader] on the road. No doubt he and other travellers are silenced under threat from speaking when entering the city, but he was able to give her a clearer image of the situation Rast faces.”

The way he spoke made it plain that there was a problem. Flos sat up on his throne, food forgotten.

“Tell me.”

“The city is destitute, my King. The [Trader] received offers from the ruling [Mayor] to exchange his wares for promises made against future payment, but refused. As he was part of the larger network of [Merchants] his goods were not taken, but he had to fend off [Thieves] along his entire trip. He was fearful of being ambushed despite the presence of his guards. What was more, not all of the thieves were [Thieves].”

It took Trey a moment to figure that out. But Flos had understood at once.

“The people are hungry?”

Orthenon nodded. He looked grim.

“They are not starving yet. But there is little trade, and the crop harvests have been bad again this year. Few cities or villages are doing well. You could say Lord Venith's lands are an exception to that rule, but it is only through his hard work his people have prospered.”

“And mine.”

Maresar looked pointedly at Orthenon. He bowed his head.

“My deepest apologies, Lady Maresar. You and your husband have been successful where few else have. In this case, the city of Rast is not dying of famine, but they are desperate and fearful of the future.”

“And the homeless and poor do starve. Is that not so, Orthenon?”

The steward didn't reply. Flos' head bowed.

"Where the average man goes without, the poor man dies. That is how it has always been. You do not need to tell me it is so."

He stared down at the Yorkshire pudding in his hand and made as if to crush it. Then Flos stared at it and ate it in one bite. Orthenon turned his head, and the servants carrying the food instantly retreated out of the room.

"Hold. Distribute that among the others with my blessings. I know you would have already, but I ask you yourselves to try some. They are quite good."

Flos' words made the servants turn. He smiled at them, and they bowed or curtsied before leaving. Then he lost his smile and looked back at the others.

"It is my fault."

Mars opened her mouth as if to protest, but she stopped. No one else had spoken. Flos nodded as he looked at the twins.

"My fault. You see, Trey, Teres, I once ruled these lands."

Trey didn't see the connection, and Flos noticed. He looked tired as he explained.

"I took these lands by force and claimed their people as my own. After my kingdom fell to pieces, some lands were absorbed by other kingdoms, or became independent. Those who swore themselves to other [Queens] or [Kings] survived. But other lands failed. Because I, their [King], had abandoned them, abandoned my throne. And as the [King] fades, so too does the land."

That was like a legend too. Trey tried to imagine it. If the [King] was healthy, the land was bountiful? Was that like King Arthur? He couldn't exactly remember any tale like that. But then Trey had a thought. What if the [King] died? Did the land die? Or...

"If the issue is that, my King, why not declare war? We could feed them with our supplies, surely."

Mars offered the idea to Flos hopefully, a hand on her sword's hilt. But Flos only shook his head.

“I will not declare war. Not now.”

Mars opened her mouth. Flos looked up.

“No war, Mars. I have no cause for it, no reason.”

“But your people are hungry. Surely that—”

“They have been hungry for a long time. Why should I care now? No. I care with every part of my heart, but it is not enough of a reason.”

Flos stood from his throne. He stepped down from the dais and paced back and forth in front of his vassals.

“I have not heard them cry out for my aid. I have not received supplication, nor seen the failure of their rulers for my own two eyes. I will not march my armies on a thought, any more than I would declare war against a nation without just cause.”

“Then you won’t fight?”

Maresar asked the question quietly. Flos looked at her.

“I would declare war for a child. I would burn a country to ash to avenge a fallen comrade. But I would never declare war for petty things like land or coin or treasure. A [King] should wage war for his desires, yes, but never for *greed*. And despite my feelings, that is how I view a war to take back my lands. They have other rulers. To take it is greed at this moment. It is a fine line. But I will not cross it.”

His vassals looked at him, some resigned, others nodding. Flos sighed. He clenched his fist, so hard Trey thought—

“Yet they are dying.”

Something red ran from his hands. It dripped onto the ground and Gazi made a small noise. It sounded like pain. Orthenon started towards Flos. The King blinked, looked down. He saw the blood from where his fingernails had pierced his skin. He waved Orthenon away.

“I am fine.”

For a second Flos stared at the blood that had dripped onto the floor. Then he looked at his hand. He gritted his teeth, and then something

changed. His head slowly turned. He looked at Trey and Teres. And then he grinned in sudden delight.

The change had caught everyone by surprise. Mars blinked and Orthenon stared curiously at his King. Maresar was watching him, but Gazi suddenly smiled again. She stared at Trey and Teres, and as the boy met one of her eyes, he saw her smiling at him. As if she'd realized something at the same time as Flos. And her smile looked genuine. It was actually not a half bad smile.

Flos tapped a finger to his lips thoughtfully, ignoring the blood. He stared at Trey and Teres, who began to have a very bad feeling, but it wasn't they who he spoke to. He turned.

"Orthenon?"

The man stood straight, clearly ready for anything. His eyes were fixed on Flos, expectant. There was a hush in the room, a waiting. A wanting.

"Yes, my King?"

"I am going for a walk. It will settle my mind, and perhaps the issue of this city. Orthenon, would you see to provisions for lunch and perhaps dinner?"

Orthenon stared at him. The twins stared at him. But Flos was suddenly smiling. Orthenon chose his words carefully.

"A walk...my King? Now?"

"Yes, I desire it. It will do me some good. Teres and Trey will come with me of course, but you are free to join me, my [Steward]. You too, Mars. Gazi. And Lady Maresar, your company would be welcome. A walk will do me good."

"For the entire day?"

"Mm."

Flos nodded. Then he beckoned to Trey, who found himself already walking with Teres towards him. Flos began strolling out of the throne room. It took his vassals a moment to react.

"My King, are you going now?"

“Your majesty—”

“Don’t fuss, Orthenon. Come if you are coming. Teres, Trey, let us walk and talk. This is a fine opportunity to talk some more, is it not? This way, out of the palace.”

He led them at a brisk walk out of the palace. Trey and Teres hurried after him, and they heard Orthenon shouting behind them.

The [Steward] didn’t follow them, but Mars, Gazi, and Maresar walked right next to Flos as he strolled out of the palace. People’s heads turned the instant they saw their King. They cheered him, but then paused when they saw who was following him.

Three of his vassals? They called out questions, but Flos just bellowed the same reply.

“I am walking! Would you care to join us?”

And what were they to say to that? Everyone in earshot immediately dropped what they were doing and began to follow their King. Trey and Teres stared. Within a hundred paces of his palace, Flos was already being followed by hundreds of people. And word was spreading like wildfire.

“Um. Where are we going?”

“Out of the city. But don’t mind the crowd. I am simply walking. Now, what were we talking about? Ah yes, heroes. Go on, tell me more stories.”

Trey stared at Gazi, Mars, and Maresar, and about a thousand people now, most following at a distance, but a good lot of them staring at him. At him. He felt lightheaded, and Teres was walking so stiffly she looked like a robot.

“Um. About who?”

“Anyone. You mentioned figures of legend. Religious figures? Yes, you mentioned that when speaking to me about Gandhi.”

“Who?”

Flos shushed Mars as he looked at Trey. Trey gulped.

“Religion. Yeah. Right. Well, there’s important—important people there all right.”

“Such as?”

“Uh...Jesus?”

“Hmm. Not a name I have heard before. Explain him to me.”

“Well...he’s Jesus. Jesus Christ. Jesus of Nazareth. Son of God. The Messiah. Emmanuel. Our savior. Uh—”

Salvation came in a figurative sense when Trey spotted someone racing after them. As Flos walked out of the gates he saw figures on horseback riding after them. Orthenon leapt from his saddle as Flos glanced at him. The King never broke stride, as a group of horsemen slowed to keep pace with him.

“You’re rather in a hurry, Orthenon. You could have caught up later. I am not walking *that* quickly.”

“Apologies, my King. But I had to organize wagons to bring provisions for you and so many people.”

Orthenon stared hard at Flos, but the King let the gaze slide right off him. He nodded genially, glancing at the riders with a frown.

“My thanks. And a few wagons to carry some small snacks and perhaps a meal would not go amiss. But I must insist on no horses.”

“No—”

Orthenon nearly bit his tongue. Flos stared at him, pretending to look annoyed. But only pretending, Trey thought.

“I am going for a walk, Orthenon. Horses rather spoil the idea. Send them away. I do not mind others coming, but it must be on foot.”

For a second Trey thought Orthenon would explode. His face flushed, but the steward strode off. After a minute the horsemen rode back towards the city. Flos grinned and turned to Trey.

“My apologies, Trey. I did not mean to interrupt you. I am sure Orthenon did not mean to either.”

Trey glanced at the steward as he hurried back over out of the corner of his eye.

“No...problem.”

“Indeed. Now, that is a curious set of titles you mentioned. Jesus of Nazareth. That is a good name for a leader. But Son of God? The gods are dead. Ah, but in your world...no. It still sounds arrogant beyond belief to my ears.”

“Well, he was. I mean, it’s a religion...”

Orthenon joined the group of people staring at Trey. Tongue tied into knots and heart pounding out of his chest, Trey tried to explain gods to a group of people who kept saying the same thing.

“The gods are dead.”

“That is a fact. But not in Trey’s world. This is fascinating. So this god of yours...what did he do?”

“All kinds of stuff. God stuff. You know, creating the world and so on...”

Trey was treated to a blank look magnified a hundredfold. He realized no one besides Teres knew what he was talking about.

So for the next three hours Trey essentially narrated a good portion of the Old Testament of the bible as he remembered it. He hadn’t exactly read it end to end, but Teres whispered in his ears—she was far too shy to speak up in front of everyone—and he told the story.

In front of a crowd of thousands. Trey didn’t know how much of the city had followed Flos out, but when he looked over his shoulders—

He did so now and saw a procession of people filling the road, stretching back as far as the eye could see. Every face was turned in his direction, and people were repeating what Flos had said, what *he* had said to the people behind them—

Trey swiveled his head forwards so he wouldn’t pass out. But Flos just kept walking with him, asking questions.

“So this god made your world.”

“Allegedly. Some people think he didn’t. Others say it was a different god—but in this religion he created the world, and his chosen people—”

“Who?”

“Hebrews.”

Teres volunteered that. Which led to a very confused explanation of the chosen people, and how they had become slaves in Egypt, then been freed by the prophet Moses. Somehow, he found himself telling Flos about how they had marched around the walls of Jericho for seven days and seven nights, much to the King’s urbane amusement.

“And then they fell down, just like that? Would that Drevish could hear that!”

He laughed and the people behind him stirred. Trey chanced another glimpse and saw people laughing as well, or just smiling to see their King laugh once more.

“But that is a fascinating story! And rather similar to the tale of Gandhi, is it not?”

“No?”

“It was nonviolent. And it gives me an ever better idea...”

Flos caught everyone staring at him and coughed. He smiled at Trey.

“There are similarities.”

“Well...afterwards the army invaded Jericho and killed everyone. Men, women, and children.”

“Ah, a practical god. And a cruel one. Or is it his prophet that ordered it? No—I am confused. I apologize, Trey, but perhaps you had better explain the aspect of god to me at a later date. I confess, I do not fully understand that issue.”

Flos sighed. He stared around, acknowledging for the first time that this was not exactly a peaceful setting. There was a hum in the air, people talking, walking, laughing—and there were *thousands* of them.

Trey glanced at Orthenon. The steward had walked with his King, listening to Trey speak. But he kept staring at his King, and Trey felt like everyone had the same question in their minds. So he asked it. Trey was surprised to find that much courage in him, but he had just (poorly) narrated a good chunk of the bible to an audience of thousands and a King.

“Um...my King?”

“I thought I told you to call me Flos.”

Mars’ jaw dropped. Trey felt cold sweat on his neck as everyone—except for Gazi for some reason—stared at him.

“S-sorry. Uh, *Flos*, how far are we walking?”

“A good ways. I believe...well, we should get to our destination in two more hours.”

“*Two more hours?*”

Trey stared at Flos incredulously. But at his words Orthenon’s brows shot together. He stared behind him, and then with a curse called out. A group of armed soldiers rushed over—on foot—and he led them back down the procession at speed.

Flos grinned.

“It took him long enough to figure it out.”

Trey stared blankly at him, as did Mars. But Maresar glanced at Gazi and the half-Gazer returned the look in a way that told Trey that those two had figured out...whatever Orthenon was figuring out.

But now Trey’s attention was ahead. He spotted a village as they walked past. It came up quickly, but what was amazing to Trey was the reaction. At first, he saw people running back and forth. They probably thought an army was coming their way, and the people that had joined Flos *were* an army in themselves. But when they saw their King, they rushed towards him.

“Ah, we’ve come to places where my name has not spread. I am sorry Trey, but you may wish to stand back.”

Flos kept walking, and met the tide of people that rushed out of houses and ran towards him. They had tears in their eyes, some of them. He met them as he walked, touching them, speaking to them. But the words he spoke to them were the same mysterious statement and offer.

“I am walking. Would you care to join me?”

Soon, the procession behind Flos had swelled by over a hundred people. And that was not the only time. Soon, Trey found himself spotting other groups of people, heading towards them at speed. Other villages in their vicinity had seen the army and Flos.

“It’s been happening all this time. Haven’t you noticed?”

Teres pointed out another group of a hundred people streaming into the procession, hugging people they recognized, flocking to their King. And bringing food. [Farmers] came with wagons hauling all kinds of food, and people rushed to come back with food to feed the huge procession.

Trey didn’t understand what was happening. But from the smile on Flos’ face, everything was happening the way the King intended it. And part of the puzzle fell into place when Orthenon came racing back to the head of the considerably longer line of people, looking fit to kill someone.

“You’re using your damn Skill!”

He shouted at Flos, causing a localized hush. Flos only grinned in reply.

“Join us, Orthenon. I take it you had to run to catch up?”

Orthenon didn’t look too tired, but some of the armed soldiers looked positively exhausted. Trey stared at Flos. The King sighed.

“I suppose I should explain. Orthenon is correct, and Gazi presumably noticed it the instant we left the city. I am using a Skill on you all.”

“What sort of Skill?”

Trey couldn’t feel anything different about himself. Flos’ eyes twinkled, and it was Orthenon who snapped a reply.

“[Rapid March]. It is a Skill that [Generals] and other leaders have. It allows an army to move twice as fast on the road. And he’s been using it since we left Reim!”

“Indeed. And thanks to the pace I’ve set, we’ve moved a bit faster than normal. Now Trey, we’ve been marching for around four hours by my count. Think about that and understand why Orthenon is so upset.”

Flos grinned at his irate steward. Trey was uncomprehending, until Teres did the math for him.

“You mean we’ve already gone over *twenty four miles by now*?”

“A bit faster. We walk closer to four miles than three by my judgment.”

After a bit of calculation with Teres, Trey’s face went pale. He couldn’t imagine going that far—and at a walking speed no less! Flos laughed at his

expression.

“It is a powerful Skill. One that allowed me to conquer this continent without growing old. I apologize for not telling you Orthenon, but we are just walking.”

“No we’re not.”

Orthenon’s face was grim as he touched the sword at his belt. Trey stared at him uneasily.

“Where are we going?”

“If I am correct, we are no more than thirty minutes away from the city of Rast.”

The steward glared at Flos, and the King casually looked in the other direction. Trey exchanged a horrified glance with Teres.

“Are we going to attack—”

“No one is attacking. I am walking.”

“To what end?”

Orthenon asked sharply. Flos didn’t reply. The steward glared, but didn’t speak, probably realizing it was futile. But Trey saw the armed soldiers he’d brought with him slowly spreading out around Flos. He began to grow very worried, but Flos’ face and posture were as relaxed as could be.

And then they were there. Trey stared at the city that had grown larger the longer they’d walked. It had been just a smudge on the horizon, growing larger with every minute. And now...

The city of Rast lay before them. The walls were tall, made of stone; the watch towers all manned. Already Trey could see people rushing to and fro on the battlements and horns blaring. But Flos did not appear concerned.

“My King?”

Orthenon looked uncharacteristically worried. He glanced at the huge line of people, clearly wishing Flos was behind more bodies.

“Should we form up those gathered here?”

Flos looked at Orthenon in surprise, but with a twinkle in his eyes.

“Form up? We aren’t leading an army, Orthenon. I am simply going for a walk.”

The steward’s eyes narrowed slightly.

“I see. And are you planning to walk through the gates?”

“I note they are closed. No, I am not welcome here, remember? I do not exist, or so the [Mayor] has said.”

“I wonder what he says now.”

Mars stared at the wall, eying a line of people standing up there. They were holding bows. Trey stared at them as well, and wondered what would happen if they fired. But it was now Flos chose to speak. He faced his vassals.

“They will not attack us.”

“Who?”

The question came from Trey before he could stop it. Flos raised his eyebrows.

“The defenders of Rast. I see them, Orthenon. I am not blind. They are armed, and they would no doubt defend their city should we attempt to storm the gates, siege the walls, or do anything so foolish. But I doubt they wish to die, so they will not fire the first shot.”

Trey looked around. The army—and it was an army, no matter what Flos said—of people was now thousands strong. Men, women, and children were gathered together. If the archers on the wall fired they would kill hundreds. Trey’s heart lurched at the thought. But he was also certain that if they fired, the archers on the walls would be dead as the people literally overwhelmed them with sheer numbers.

And the people on the walls knew that too. There was an army here, even if it was an army of noncombatants, big enough to take the entire city. That was why a messenger raced out of the gates, waving a white flag. He came asking for Flos’ demands, and got a very strange, but predictable response.

“I am simply walking.”

The messenger was a pale-faced young man on horseback who stared at Mars, Gazi, Orthenon, and especially Flos as if he were staring at ghosts or monsters.

“But you are—”

“I am going for a walk.”

Flos said it calmly, looking the young man in the eye as his mount shied away from the vast number of people. Flos waved a hand at his followers.

“I am simply walking. These people have chosen to join me. Tell your [Mayor] that I do not intend to enter the city unless invited. You have a King’s word on it. I would swear that in blood if it were not so inconvenient. Tell him we will not attack without being provoked. Make that clear to him.”

“I—I shall.”

The young man raced back into the city. Trey saw the people on the walls reacting. They lowered their bows slightly, but they kept watching. Every eye was on Flos now, and everyone was waiting. He claimed to be walking, but the King of Destruction had to be lying. Surely he was going to attack or...

Flos turned. His eyes found Trey. For some reason, Trey had expected that too. Flos walked over to him, and bent slightly.

“Do you know what I am going to do, Trey?”

“Walk?”

It was a stupid response, but Flos laughed.

“Yes, but what else?”

“I have no idea.”

Trey thought there was something niggling at his brain, but he couldn’t put the pieces together. Something about today. About Rast, about the hungry people...it was no good. The current situation was far too distracting.

Flos grinned.

“What if I gave you a hint? One hint, Trey.”

“Okay.”

The King leaned down and whispered to Trey.

“I had intended it another way, but your story about that god of Hebrews gave me an idea. But I rather think that what can be done in seven days I can do in seven hours.”

Trey stared at him. And then his eyes widened.

“You don’t—”

“My people!”

Flos strode away from Trey, practically laughing with delight. He raised his hands and they cheered him. The people on the walls watched, probably terrified out of their minds as thousands of voices shouted Flos’ name.

Already Trey could see people, other people, gathered at the closed portcullis. Civilians, not soldiers, peering to see. They had to know an army was at their gates, but not why. They were desperate to know, fearful, yes, but curious. And that was what Flos wanted.

“What is he doing?”

Teres seized Trey’s arm, but Orthenon took her place. The steward’s face was focused, and his hand was gripping his sword’s hilt.

“Trey, is our King planning to attack?”

“No, no, he’s not! He’s planning to march!”

“On the city?”

“No—he’s—”

Flos’ voice answered everything. The King pointed towards the city and bows raised. But he wasn’t pointing *at* the city.

“Around the walls! Let us march! Come!”

He began walking towards the city. Everyone stared, but Trey found himself walking behind Flos, towards the armed defenders. He could feel the tension rising as the horde of people walked towards the walls. The bowmen had arrows nocked and Trey could feel crawling fear all over him.

But no one loosed. The King had said he would not enter, would not attack. If they fired, they would die. That had to be in their thoughts. And

Flos had to know they didn't want to die. But what a gamble to make! The King kept approaching the gates, and then he suddenly turned left.

There was a ripple of surprise as his procession followed him. But now Flos was walking around the walls, following it closely. Trey could see the people on the walls racing to catch up. But that was all Flos was doing. He just walked around the walls of the city, slowly. That was all he was going to do, Trey knew.

He was going to walk and bring the walls down.

It started when Flos turned, mid-stride. He walked backwards, and raised his voice so everyone could hear. He had a massive voice when he cared to use it and Trey, walking just behind him, winced as Flos shouted.

“My people! We have come to Rast, but they will not open their gates for me! The [Mayor] claims that I still lie asleep! But you have seen my face! You know I have woken!”

His voice carried across the crowd, and huge cheers and shouting erupted as he spoke. Trey glanced up and saw, high above, pale faces staring down. Everyone had heard. Flos raised his arms, and the sound grew louder. People were cheering him, shouting for their King. And then he asked the question.

“Who is your King?”

“*Flos!*”

“*The King of Destruction!*”

“*Flos of Reim!*”

Countless voices roared it. But that wasn't enough. Flos raised his voice. He roared at his subjects, his people.

“What is my name?”

They all screamed the answer at the same time. Every voice, every child, every woman and man. A single word, multiplied thousands of times.

“*Flos!*”

This time the word split the air. It was thunder, sound given form. Flos raised his hand into the air and the sound was deafening. Flos kept walking, leading his people around the walls. He roared again.

“Who is it that rules these lands?”

“*Flos!*”

Trey shouted it too, and heard the ringing in his ears, the same word, all around him. It wasn't just coming from the people with him. Trey heard it from *inside* the city. People were shouting his name.

“I am the King of Destruction!”

Flos bellowed the words so the people in the city could hear. His voice was louder as he halted and raised both hands up.

“And I have returned!”

Trey heard a loud sound, and then nothing. Something was ringing loudly. He shook his head and saw Teres doing the same next to him.

Slowly, noise came back. But it was thunderous, a beating wave. Flos marched on, and the wild cheering continued. But not for long.

“March! March, my subjects! Call out my name for the world to hear!”

Flos shouted and began to stamp his foot every fourth step. Without needing more than that, every person in the crowd did the same. Soon the sound of their fourth step was like a small earthquake. Then someone began shouting.

“*Flos!*”

Every fourth step, they shouted his name. And then it really was like the entire world was shaking. Trey found himself doing the same. Every fourth step he landed as hard as he could and the word burst from his lips. He was shaking with wild energy.

“Flos!”

The walls of Rast shook with the sound. Not in actuality, but Trey thought the mortar and stone should have been knocked loose from the sound. He stomped, and shouted. The word was deafening.

“Flos!”

This time he knew he heard the word bellowed from within. And then the King raised his arms. He stopped in front of the gates, and shouted.

“People of Rast! Who is your King!?”

And the walls of the city came tumbling down.

“Perhaps it was simply a metaphor.”

When Trey could hear again, when the shouting and chaos had ended, hours, years later, that was what Flos said to him. It was what he said when the gates were thrown open, the people of Rast, his people, standing on the walls and cheering, the guardsmen and soldiers having either thrown down their arms and surrendered, or joined the people. They had opened the gates and flooded out, shouting and calling their King’s name.

The city was now the King of Destruction’s. The people had turned on their leaders, overwhelmed the few people who would have kept the gates barred. They had remembered their King, the starving poor, the homeless, and the hungry citizens. They had risen, and the walls of Rast had fallen in a metaphorical sense as they opened the gates for their King.

Not without blood. Trey heard it later. Some people had fought and died to prevent the gates being opened. The [Mayor] had fled, and been torn apart by a mob. That was the darkness in Flos’ victory.

But there was much to celebrate as well. Because the first thing Flos did was order Orthenon to ensure no one would starve. Already riders were

racing back towards Reim, to return with food, and the warehouses were being opened and food carefully distributed to those in dire need.

They did not fling open the doors and let everyone eat their fill. Orthenon saw to that. In quick order he'd established control and posted guards on the warehouses. People would be fed, but it would be sensibly, and without exhausting the food they had. Winter would soon be here, and every sack of grain counted.

And yet, it was still a celebration in the streets. Trey still heard cheering, or he would have if his ears were properly working. They'd given up at some point and he wasn't sure if he'd ever hear things properly again.

But he felt it in the air. Something electric and *alive*. Flos was walking his streets, still walking, but stopping to greet his people. He had an escort of soldiers around him, more to keep the King from being surrounded forever than anything else.

Trey sat on the battlements, sipping a drink. It was just water, but it was refreshingly cool, hauled up from a deep well. Teres wasn't here; she was with Orthenon, following him about, watching him work.

She had a crush. But Trey was fine with being alone, for a little bit. He had chosen a quiet part of the wall, and so he was surprised when someone found him.

Gazi the Omniscient climbed up and sat next to Trey without a word. He stared at her. He thought about edging away, but didn't.

"The city rejoices."

The Gazer had a cup in her hands. Trey looked. It was water too. The Gazer's head was staring down below into the city, away from Trey but she'd still seen Trey.

"There is not enough alcohol to celebrate. And so I make do with this. It is no hardship."

"Oh. I uh—"

She turned her head then, to smile at him. Trey blinked at her as two of Gazi's eyes focused on him. She was smiling as always, but there wasn't anything scary about her right now. She was just smiling. Like a normal person. It was disconcerting, coming from her.

“He brought down the walls quickly, didn’t he? It was seven days in your story, wasn’t it?”

“That’s right.”

“But in your story the walls themselves fell. Is that the difference between a [King] and a god?”

She didn’t wait for a reply. Gazi took a drink from her cup and stared down into the city. Trey had a feeling her eyes were following Flos, wherever he was. After a few minutes, Gazi spoke.

“This is what it was always like. This is why we followed him. Not simply because he was a [King]. But because of this.”

“What? Oh.”

It was a question that Trey hadn’t ever asked aloud. Gazi nodded at him.

“You have seen him as he is now. As he struggles to return to what he was. But we remember. This is why we followed him, we seven, his subjects. For these moments. For what he could do. Because he was a King.”

Trey had no answer to that, nothing he could say. But it wasn’t a statement that demanded an answer. He and Gazi sat on the battlements until the sun set. He rode back with Teres on a horse, reaching Reim in just over an hour. Apparently, the people who had followed Flos marched into the night, but met riders and wagons coming their way with food to keep them supplied. And their King walked with them the entire way, speaking with his people.

And so as Trey staggered to his room, before he fell asleep onto his bed, which was actually Teres’ and she fell asleep onto his, he heard it. The whispers.

They ran through the hallways, through the entire palace. They swept into the city, out of the roads, from person to person, by spell and letter. A rumor.

The King of Destruction was awake. He had returned, truly. And there was something else. He had taken a city. Not just taken it—he had brought the walls down. No, he had conquered it with just one word. He had

stormed the city and taken it without a single life lost. He had marched up to the gates and brought down the walls with a single word.

That was rumor. But there was truth in it. And the truth was that the King of Destruction had awoken. It was no longer gossip, idle speculation, or a secret known by the few and powerful. Now it was a shout, and it spread like wildfire to the people who had waited for this day. It could no longer be ignored, and they called his name once more.

Flos. The King of Destruction.

He had awoken. He had returned at last. Trey slept with that knowledge ringing in his ears and heard.

The declaration of war reached the palace the next day.

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Trey was sitting in the banquet hall with Teres, trying to explain what a shortcake was to an interested audience of servants and a harried [Cook] when Gazi found him. The half-Gazer strode through the crowd and jerked her thumb.

“Come.”

It was indicative of her personality that no one asked questions. Trey and Teres were following Gazi out of the banquet hall in an instant.

“Why are we—”

Gazi’s head turned and she cut Teres off with an answer.

“A messenger has come for my lord Flos. He desires you to hear what is being said.”

“And wh—”

“War.”

The word precipitated a *crash* of broken pottery. A woman who’d been carrying a load of dirty dishes dropped them when she heard the word. Gazi glanced at her and the woman immediately bowed.

“War?”

Trey said it faintly. War? Now? Of course, Flos was the King of Destruction, but—

“It will be war.”

One of Gazi’s eyes turned to follow the servant as she bent to pick up the broken shards. She didn’t say anything, but Trey would have bet his eyeteeth—since he didn’t have any actual money—that the woman would be telling everyone in earshot as soon as she was out of sight. And Gazi probably knew that, but she walked on.

As it turned out, war had already been declared by the time the twins and Gazi reached the throne room. They entered to hear shouting, and saw a

young man wearing leather armor, covered in a thin layer of dust and sweat, shouting at Flos.

“—will not kneel to you! Hellios has risen, and our soldiers are marching towards this city at this very moment!”

Flos sat on his throne, flanked by Orthenon and Mars as he stared down at the messenger.

“So Queen Calliope desires war?”

The young man’s eyes blazed up at Flos. He didn’t seem to notice the twins as they edged around the room, nor Gazi as she strode up to the throne and took a place next to Orthenon.

“You know she does. Her hatred of you burns no less brightly than my own, King Flos of Reim. You killed my father, and for that you will answer at last.”

His father. Trey looked at the young man. Was he a [Prince]? Certainly, Flos seemed to be treating him like one, to let him yell at him in front of his vassals. But why had a [Prince] come himself? He certainly wasn’t attired like one, and he looked like he’d been on the road for hours, if not days.

“That I killed King Treland is reason enough to hate. But I would have thought your mother had more sense. She knows what war brings. She has seen it once. I doubt she would be foolish to wish for it again.”

His words made the young prince flush with fury.

“We have held our peace because you slept, in cowardice. But now that you are awake, it is war, Flos of Reim!”

“And why were you sent? Did your mother fear I would slay her messenger?”

“I took his place. I had to see the truth of it myself, that you were awake. I wanted to lay eyes on my father’s killer myself.”

The young man’s eyes burned as he put his hand on the sword at his waist. No one moved, despite the threat. Orthenon stared coldly down at the prince, Mars with intensity, watching his hands. Gazi looked bored; only one eye was on him. Two were for her King and one—

Trey shuddered. One was watching him and Teres. Watching them react to the prince.

“Tell me your name, bold son of Calliope. You have not given it. If I am to be at war with the kingdom of Hellios, I would know who brings such tidings.”

“I am [Prince] Siyal of Hellios. And I swear to you, King Flos, that I will have vengeance for—”

“Your father. Yes, I heard.”

Flos sighed. He stared down at Siyal with an expression Trey and Teres hadn't seen on him before. It wasn't anger. It was more like grim intensity. It was a very kingly expression in that sense, but there was something else in the way he looked at Siyal.

Disappointment.

“So you seek my head as a matter of vengeance. You would not be the first, nor the last. But why for Treland? He was not worthy of it. Far better to come after me for those countless thousands I slew, or your shattered kingdom. Why waste hatred for the death of a worthless king, even if he was a father?”

“How *dare* you.”

Siyal's eyes blazed and he actually unsheathed his sword a fraction. At once, Orthenon and Mars both reached for their sword hilts. The prince halted, eyeing both of them.

“I did not come here to bare my blade, King Flos. But one more word of insult and I will shed my blood, regardless of the odds!”

“I hear your words, Siyal. But what I said was no insult. It was the truth.”

Flos cut off Siyal as the young man looked as if he might truly rush the throne. He stood up and stared down at the young man.

“You think your father was a man worth avenging? He was not.”

The King of Destruction raised his voice over the young man's voice.

“Silence! He. Was. Not. Because I am a [King], know that I speak the truth. Your father was no hero, no great ruler, boy. He was a fool and a monster. You have a King’s word on that.”

“Liar!”

It was amazing, Trey thought, that Siyal could shout that at Flos, much less to his face. A King’s word...but Flos didn’t grow angry. He just stared Siyal down, and the [Prince] lost a bit of his bravado in the silence that followed.

“I will not lie, even for the fallen. That your father died does not change the nature of his sin. Neither did his Class. He treated his subjects like animals—no, worse than that.”

“He was a [King]! He deserved an honorable death, not an execution on the battlefield! How he ruled was no business of yours!”

“His people cried out for justice. They came to me, begging for protection, to bring down a king that cared more for his own wealth and that of his friends than his people. Is that the man you admire, Siyal? Or did your mother never tell you of his failures, only my crimes? I went to war for the thousands who died under his rule, not to steal land or wealth.”

Siyal’s face had gone pale as Flos spoke. He pointed a shaking finger at Flos.

“I will not listen to your lies. You are no worthy [King]. You dare to talk of a [King]’s duties when you abandoned your own kingdom? You—you have no right to speak of my father to me.”

Flos stared down at Siyal, that same cold disappointment in his expression. He shook his head slowly.

“You and I use the truth like blades. But I have the courage to face it. My failure and who I am does not change reality. Your father—”

“Silence!”

Siyal did draw his blade, then. And Orthenon and Mars did the same. They leapt off the throne’s dais, surrounding Siyal from both ends. He whirled to face them, face pale but jaw set.

“Orthenon. Mars. Enough.”

Flos stopped his vassals with one hand. He looked down at the [Prince] as Orthenon and Mars stepped back, sheathing their blades.

“You are fearless, Prince Siyal. But it takes more than courage to make a man. But at least you have that. Your father had not that.”

It was cruel. Flos’ words were harsh and cutting, and Trey saw the marks they left on Siyal. They cut deep, because Trey knew they were true. There was something in Flos’ voice, the way he spoke that made the truth self-evident. And some part of Siyal knew it.

The prince sheathed his sword. Tears stood out in the corners of his eyes as he glared up at Flos. His voice was rough, but steady.

“You have heard my message. Hellios declares war with Reim. My duty here is done. When we next meet, it will be under banner, bearing arms.”

He pointed at Flos.

“I will find you on the battlefield. I will hunt you down and claim your head with my sword.”

The King didn’t blink.

“I shall try to spare the effort to pick your face out from the legions of my enemies.”

He lifted a hand in dismissal. Siyal turned and stormed from the room, face crimson. All that time he had not glanced once at the twins. They were beneath his notice.

The two double doors closed behind Prince Siyal of Hellios, and Flos sat down slowly upon his throne. Only then did Mars and Orthenon turn to face him. After a second, Gazi stepped down and joined them.

And then Trey saw the curtains near one of the balconies move. He stared as Lady Maresar pushed them back. She calmly walked over to the others, putting an arrow back in the quiver at her side as she did.

Flos glanced at Maresar, at Gazi, and then the twins as they hesitantly came to stand before his throne. He smiled a bit at them, wearily.

“And so it begins.”

“War.”

This time Trey said the word and felt a chill. It was strange. One person said it, and suddenly it was true. He glanced at the doors Siyal had left through.

“Was he really a [Prince]?”

“Oh yes.”

Everyone in the room except for Teres nodded at once. Mars grinned as she tapped her chin.

“Did you see the way he kept it raised the entire time he was talking? The royals have a way of talking and standing that just screams their class. It makes you want to trip them whenever they walk past.”

Orthenon frowned at Mars before turning to Trey.

“I am surprised he came alone, but yes, that was [Prince] Siyal. Doubtless he must have come here against his mother’s wishes.”

“Calliope knows I would not stoop to ransoming her son.”

Flos looked mildly annoyed by the implication. Orthenon bowed to him.

“Of course. But the roads are not safe, my King. He must have rushed here.”

“I saw his horse as he rode in. It looked dead. That fool probably rode it at a gallop all the way here.”

Maresar’s lip curled and Flos shook his head. He sat with his back straight against his throne, staring at the ceiling.

“Yet his message was plain, and perhaps warranted such actions, at least in his mind. War.”

“It has come at last.”

Gazi’s eyes glittered with excitement. Orthenon and Mars nodded, and both looked...eager. It wasn’t a thought Trey would have associated with war, not in his world. But there was a spark of that in Maresar’s eyes, and when Flos looked down—

Trey could see it there too. That awful glimmer, that silent spark of terrible things. Terrible, glorious things.

“War.”

When he said it, Trey got goose bumps again. Only this time, Flos did not seize his sword and rush out of the room. Instead, he sighed.

“We have much to do.”

He looked at his steward.

“Orthenon, apprise me as we walk. Mars, spread the word. Lady Maresar, if you will send messengers to the furthest villages? We must ready my subjects to retreat behind the city’s walls at once. Gazi, be watchful as always. And you, Trey, Teres...”

He turned and the twins tensed with anticipation. Flos smiled.

“You have seen my kingdom in decay, at peace, such as it is. Now see its true heart. We prepare for war, at last. It is time to break my long slumber, my endless fast.”

He paused, and only Trey noticed the slight rolling of his eyes, and the look of chagrin on Flos’ face. He turned.

“Come. Follow.”

And they did.

To Trey’s surprise, the rest of the day was not filled with people running about and general confusion. Oh, some people moved faster than normal, but Flos walked down his corridors at the same pace as always, and took time to greet the people he met as usual.

He had an explanation when Trey asked.

“War has been declared. But though Hellios is far closer than the lands of the Emperor of Sands, an army will not appear on my doorstep tomorrow. Or the day after, for that matter.”

“That is the convenience of a formal declaration of war.”

Orthenon nodded as he stepped out of a cluster of servants and messengers. He was the one working hardest, and Trey and Teres got to see exactly what going to war meant you had to do.

The first and most important thing was to make sure everyone knew there was a war going on. It wasn't as if everyone had a telephone—or a [Mage] capable of receiving a [Message] spell. Within the hour, people on horseback were racing to all parts of the kingdom, bearing the news of war.

But that didn't mean people were about to come rushing towards the castle with swords in hand, ready to fight, either. It did mean they harvested any food available, and made preparations to leave their villages and towns at once if an army came their way.

“You see, Teres, Trey, an enemy army will strip the countryside. Even if an army does not attack civilians—and there are many which would slaughter any of my subjects they came across—they will destroy villages and kill by their simple passing. Once we know from which direction the army approaches, we will begin evacuating those in need.”

Flos told them this in between readying his capital for war. There was so much to do he was giving Orthenon a hand in organizing. The walls had to be inspected, soldiers manning the battlements and watchful at all times, and gear had to be distributed. Not everyone walked around ready for battle like Mars—most people found wearing anything heavier than cloth fairly tiring, let alone plate armor or chainmail.

And not everyone got that, either. Helmets were in short supply, armor needed patching, some weapons could use a whetstone, while others had a broken haft. Potions needed distributing, pack horses and other animals found to haul all of the army's supplies and equipment—the list went on and on. It wasn't as if Orthenon and Flos had been neglecting doing any of this, but they'd had an entire kingdom to get working again. Now, all of these preparations were the first order of business.

Amid all of the busy work, Trey felt like the most useless lump. He could only watch as Flos strode around, taking care of matters that Trey wouldn't have thought to address. At least Teres could say she was helping a bit—she scribbled down notes for Orthenon as he assessed the number of soldiers they had, how many saddles were in working repair, and so on.

Not so for Flos and Trey. The King of Destruction didn't use lists, and he didn't need another person to run messages for him. He told Trey that he just needed him to watch what he was doing. So Trey did.

He watched as the second declaration of war reached Flos in the throne room. And then the third. And the fourth.

This time the messengers came together. Two delegations of armed soldiers approached the gates and demanded entry. The bulk of the soldiers remained at the gate, watched warily by soldiers from the walls, as a smaller delegation entered the throne room.

One man came alone, sweeping into the room with a bow towards the throne, his silk robes swirling around him as he approached the throne and then bowed again. The second man marched in with four warriors at his back, a scroll of parchment sealed with wax in his hands.

“I take it you two come for the same reason?”

Flos sat on his throne, staring down at the two unlike messengers. It was the man in robes who spoke first.

“Your Majesty, I come bearing word from my home country of Germina. I am humbly [Ambassador] Illius, authorized to speak for the Quarass on matters of state.”

Flos nodded at the man as Trey stared at Ambassador Illius. He sounded like a complete *ponce*. That was, until Trey realized he probably was all the things he said. So...just weird.

“What does the Quarass will, Ambassador Illius?”

Flos knew. Everyone in the room knew. But somehow, the good ambassador managed to stretch a single statement into multiple sentences.

“The Quarass has determined that a state of war exists between our two nations. Having searched for an alternative, she has concluded that none may be found save by arms. We declare war upon the nation of Reim and I am tasked with ensuring this message is delivered to his Majesty Flos so that an understanding is reached.”

Flos nodded as Trey rubbed at his ears and Mars yawned. The King turned to the man standing stiffly next to Illius.

“And do you come with the same tidings, messenger?”

“Your Majesty, it is not for me to say. I am entrusted with this letter, and may not return until I have seen it to your hands.”

The man stepped forwards, offering the scroll. Not directly to Flos, but to Orthenon, who came down to receive it. Only after the steward had checked the scroll—for dangerous magic or poison, perhaps—did he deliver it to Flos.

The King broke the seal and read from the scroll as everyone in the room waited. It took him only a few seconds, mainly because Trey saw his eyes skimming down the very long scroll all the way to the bottom. Then he rolled it up and nodded. He said one word.

“War.”

The ambassador and messenger both bowed their heads. Flos looked down on them. Trey was practically eating his fingers. Three nations had declared war? *Three*? But the King of Destruction looked as if he’d expected nothing less.

“I have read your senate’s declaration of war, messenger of Xar. And I have heard your words, Ambassador Illius. You may go.”

They went.

Apparently, all of Flos’ vassals and Flos himself had known more nations would be declaring war. And apparently, Teres had figured it out as well, which meant only Trey was caught off guard.

“Well it makes sense don’t it?”

She explained it to Trey when he pulled her aside—for what Trey had assumed to be a mutual freak out, but which became a stern lecture. Teres frowned at Trey as if not predicting war was a fault.

“You heard how scary Flos is supposed to be, didn’t you? Even if they think he’s just woken up, no one nation is going to pick a fight. It’s

probably a lot of them that decided to gang up.”

Just how many was a surprise to both of the twins, though. Because not an hour after the two delegates had left, another declaration of war came to Reim. This one came in a box, and it was delivered by a [Runner].

In fact, it took a while to get to Flos. A servant came with it as Flos was walking around his city with Orthenon, making sure there were no glaring gaps in the wall. Only when Orthenon had spoken with the man did the small box reach the King.

“Is it another declaration of war?”

“I believe so, my King.”

Flos sighed. He eyed the package.

“I think I know which nation this one comes from. Elmvettelashar. Or whatever the name is.”

Orthenon shook his head at Flos’ incorrect pronunciation as the King took the package and began to unwrap it. It was tied with a bit of twine, and the package itself was a cheap wood box, hardly fit for a King. Trey edged away from the box nervously.

“What about traps? What if there’s a b—poison or something?”

Flos shook his head.

“This came through the Runner’s Guild. They do not allow such deliveries. It would ruin their neutrality. And this is a declaration of war, I am sure of it, as is Orthenon. Less formal perhaps, but cheaper. Let us see what they have—ah.”

Flos’ hands had unwrapped the parcel. Trey recoiled and Teres clapped a hand over her mouth when they saw—and smelled—what was inside.

The King’s face didn’t change as he showed the contents of the box to Orthenon. The steward stared with disgust at the slightly rotted heart in the box. Flos handed it to him and Orthenon immediately handed it to a servant with orders to burn the box and everything in it. Only then did Flos notice Trey and Teres’ pale faces.

“It’s not a human heart. I think it’s probably a goat’s.”

Teres was able to ask the question. Trey felt if he opened his mouth something else would come pouring out.

“But—why—?”

“Ah. It’s an ancient tradition. This is the way the people of Elmvett declare war. In the past they would have used a real heart, but this is probably more convenient.”

The King waved away the smell and the twins had to go sit down for a bit. That was the fourth declaration of war. The fifth and sixth arrived the next day. But before Trey heard them, the first assassin was discovered in the castle.

Trey awoke the next morning to a scream. He rushed out of his room, and Teres ran out after him with the sword Orthenon had given her. They followed the raised voice and people running and found Gazi.

She was kneeling over the body of a child.

Her sword was drawn, and there was blood on it. Trey knew what had happened, but he didn’t *want* to know. He stared at Gazi with dull horror beating in his chest.

She straightened, after wiping her sword on the dead child’s clothing. She turned and paused when she saw Trey and Teres staring at her. But then her head turned. She bowed as Flos strode towards her down the corridor.

The King stopped when he saw the body. He stared at Gazi, and Trey saw his face pale. He knelt by the small corpse and the pooling blood. She had raven hair. It was a she. Flos gazed down at the child and then up at Gazi. He sighed, and it was as if part of his heart left with it.

“Ah, Gazi. Did she have to die?”

The half-Gazer bowed her head. Then she produced something and held it out carefully to Flos. He took it.

It was a dagger, coated with something dark and brown on the tip. Flos didn't touch it. He only stared at the dagger and then dropped it.

“An [Assassin].”

Maresar spoke softly behind Trey and Teres. They turned to her. She had an arrow nocked as she stared at the child's body. There was no sorrow there, just concentration.

There was on Orthenon's face, and Mars'. They came at a run, Orthenon first, Mars slower, running with sword and shield in hand, wearing her plate armor as always. Mars turned away from the body and Orthenon sheathed his sword harder than necessary. Flos stared at the crowd of servants and soldiers, and then at the twins.

Neither one of them could look at the body. But they couldn't look away. Trey stared at Gazi. And then at the child.

“How?”

Flos looked at Gazi. She answered softly. As if by reflex, she smiled as she spoke, that same, damned smile that Trey hated so much. It wasn't a smile. It was a grin. Something devoid of actual emotion.

A mask.

“A group of refugees arrived last night. They claimed to have been driven from their village by soldiers. They had marched for days. Some died. They were all starving.”

Orthenon rubbed at his face.

“I heard the report. I ordered them fed and given a place to sleep. And this child—”

Gazi turned to him, looking vaguely surprised.

“You knew they would send assassins the moment my lord woke.”

He didn't reply. He just stared at the body and turned away. Orthenon walked down the corridor as Flos stood. He stared down at the child's body and then looked at Gazi.

“I ask much of you.”

He did not say thank you, or that it was a job well done. If he did, Trey thought Teres would have attacked him with the sword in her hands. He did not know what he would have done. Gazi nodded once. Then she turned. She sheathed her sword and began to walk in the other direction down the corridor.

Someone covered the child's body with a cloth. Someone else carefully picked up the dagger and wrapped it in several layers so the deadly poisoned edge was not visible. Flos walked towards the twins. They stared at him.

This was the feeling Trey remembered. This was it, pure and raw and sudden, cutting through the vague acceptance of this world, all the time he'd had to adjust to a new reality. Suddenly, he truly was a stranger in a strange land.

Until he remembered they did this very thing where he came from too. Not at home, but in his world.

Flos looked into his face. The King was silent for a while. Then he spoke.

"Some nations use assassins, Trey, Teres. This reeks of Germina. Ambassador Illius' people train such killers and the Quarass...she would do this."

That was all he said. He turned away and began walking towards his throne room. It took a long time before Trey and Teres moved. And when they did, they stumbled. They walked along the stone corridors, hearing the hushed voices and knew they did not belong. They did not want to belong.

Not here. And Trey remembered Gazi's smile.

And he hated her for it.

There were more shadows in the throne room that day. Flos sat heavily on his throne, and he did not smile. The fifth declaration of war reached him as Orthenon was speaking quietly.

“War with Ultea. A rider rode up to the gates and shouted it.”

Orthenon relayed the message, a look of disgust on his face.

“Barbarians. They didn’t confirm it was a true messenger from their nation. Anyone could have claimed the same.”

Flos was in no mood to debate the issue. He clenched one hand as he sat on his throne, looking as though he would have rather drawn the sword at his side instead. It was another plain sword from his armory. Not enchanted.

Not like Gazi’s.

“It is enough that I hear war declared, Orthenon. When we see their banners marching, we will know the truth.”

The steward nodded. Flos turned towards the twins, standing like ghosts. His voice softened, but he did speak to them of war.

“It is not like your world. There are no signed treaties, at least, none that require my signature. Some nations do send formal missives, but many are like Ultea and use actions, not words. Other nations are subtler, but some do not bother with declarations at all.”

The twins made no reply.

The sixth declaration was the most dramatic of all, and if it hadn’t been for Orthenon and Flos, Trey and Teres would never have spotted it. The King was walking out of his palace when he uttered an oath and stared up. Orthenon stared up and the twins barely saw a flaming arrow before it struck the wall of Flos’ palace. It did not shatter, but rather dropped downwards, out of sight.

Flos strode to the battlements. Trey and Teres saw a rider with a bow in hand. They had shot the arrow at the walls. A banner—dark blue, emblazoned with a white bird clutching a second flaming arrow in its talons—flapped wildly, attached to the horse’s saddle.

The meaning was clear. War, from a sixth nation. By this point Trey was numb to it.

Flos stared at the rider, hands gripping the battlements tightly. He turned his head towards his steward.

“Orthenon. If that arrow struck one of my subjects, catch that rider and kill her.”

The man nodded and strode away. Trey stared at Flos. The King’s eyes followed the rider until she had vanished. She was allowed to go; no one had been harmed by the arrow as it fell to earth.

Twenty minutes later, Flos was in the war room with all of his vassals, including Lady Maresar and the twins. He sat on a large chair clearly meant for him, staring darkly at his steward as the man spoke.

“Ultea, Oblinat, Xar, Germina, Hellios, and Elmvett have all declared war against us now, my King. It is safe to assume they have formed a coalition and will send an army of combined forces to assault the city. I have received reports that most of the armies are on the march already.”

Trey felt a cold pit in his stomach, but Flos just nodded as if that was inconsequential. Trey couldn’t help but keep glancing left, to where Gazi stood with arms folded in one corner of the war room. No one was standing with her. Teres was deliberately sitting with her back to the half-Gazer.

Now one of Gazi’s eyes turned towards Trey. He looked away quickly.

“Will any more declarations arrive?”

“Doubtful, my King. These are all the ones I had predicted.”

Orthenon stared grimly at the map of Chandrar as Flos stood up and paced back and forth in front of the table. He turned to Orthenon.

“After yesterday, how many soldiers do we have in our army?”

Orthenon paused. He looked at Teres, and she was the one who answered.

“Just over six thousand soldiers. Six thousand two hundred and fifty... six.”

Flos nodded.

“Six thousand soldiers. A fine number, all things considered.”

“But very small.”

Mars mumbled that. She was playing with a dagger in her gauntleted hands. She hadn’t spoken much before this; Trey hadn’t seen her around the castle as Flos and Orthenon were moving about. Orthenon eyed her and nodded shortly.

“We will have more. Possibly as many as two thousand from the refugees headed towards the city. Not all will be raw recruits either; there may be a good handful of veteran warriors among their number.”

“Continue adding them to the ranks of our army as needed, Orthenon. But will it be enough?”

“I do not know, my lord. I can only work off of rough estimates of each nation’s strengths, but from what scouts and fleeing refugees have said, each nation has sent around ten thousand soldiers to do battle.”

Ten *thousand* soldiers. Trey felt his heart stop for a second. Against six thousand—

Flos nodded. His mouth twisted wryly.

“Ten thousand soldiers used to be an army large enough for any one nation. Not so these days, I suppose.”

“Not to go hunting for the King of Destruction’s head.”

Gazi shifted as all eyes turned towards her. She looked at Orthenon.

“Do you have a total number?”

Orthenon paused.

“One claim puts the army at seventy thousand.”

Someone made a small sound. Trey realized it had been him. Orthenon’s head turned towards Trey and his tone changed, becoming slightly more reassuring. It didn’t work.

“That number is probably highly inaccurate. There may well be over fifty thousand soldiers marching—perhaps as many as eighty thousand depending on whether it was an experienced [Scout] that counted or a [Farmer]. But of that number, a decent portion won’t fight in battle.”

“So? We’re still dead, right?”

Trey didn’t want to be a downer, but he had to speak the blindingly obvious truth when he saw it. Flos drummed his hands on his chair’s armrest as he sat back down.

“[Porters], [Cooks], [Hostlers], and [Healers]...they would account for several thousand depending on the size of each army. Still, Trey is correct that we are largely outnumbered.”

He had to say the situation was hopeless, right? Even if he was the King of Destruction...Trey waited, but Flos just shook his head.

“Putting numbers aside for the moment...Orthenon, based off of your knowledge of the nations that sent these armies, how many high-level warriors are we likely to encounter? Any specialty troops?”

“None that I know of. I would assume they would be obvious if they were included, but it seems that Germina and Oblinat have declined to commit their most experienced forces.”

“Wise of them.”

Maresar whispered that. Flos nodded. He looked at the twins. He was still explaining. Still explaining, as if this meant...nothing.

“A battle is not decided merely by numbers in this world, Trey, Teres. Nor in yours, I suspect. But aside from the quality of arms and strategy, the existence of high-level warriors and mages can change the course of an entire battle. In fact, the enemy [General] alone can tip the scales between victory and defeat if his level is high enough.”

“So can armies geared towards a certain type of fighting, where all their soldiers have the same kind of class. Highly mobile armies, armies where the most common soldier knows a Tier 2 spell...if we don’t see them here, it is to our advantage.”

Orthenon’s calmness was getting on Trey’s nerves.

“But they have over *fifty thousand*—”

“Trey. I understand your concerns, but we must appraise our enemy fully before worrying.”

Flos gently patted Trey on the shoulder and let him take his seat. Trey sat, fidgeting on the chair as Flos looked at Orthenon. The steward continued.

“The highest level [General] in the region would be [Duke] Balimar Wulten. I assume he will lead the coalition army.”

“An aristocratic general?”

“No.”

Orthenon shook his head to Flos’ clear disappointment.

“He gained the [Duke] class from achieving distinction in battle, not at birth. To my knowledge his one main class is [General].”

“A pity.”

Flos sighed. He looked at Gazi.

“So. We know there may be as many as eighty thousand, and no outstanding units have been spotted. I hate to ask it of you, Gazi, but you are our highest-level [Scout]...”

She was already ready. Gazi bowed to Flos, eyeing the position of the army on the map.

“I will appraise their forces and return shortly, my lord.”

She would have strode out there and then, but Flos caught her arm. He stared down at Gazi.

“Go safely, my dear Gazi. Take no risks for me. I cannot bear to lose you too.”

She smiled at him. Smiled in a real way, so happy that it made Trey hurt to see it.

“I will be careful.”

Then she was gone. In lieu of better knowledge, Orthenon declared the meeting adjourned. He began shifting forces along the north east wall in preparation for the battle. And he sent more riders out after Gazi had gone, although not to scout for soldiers.

“There are streams of refugees and villagers flooding the road to the city, my King. They have been forced out of their homes. Not just the ones

in your lands—anyone who refuses to renounce you as King has been forced out.”

Flos paused.

“Were any killed?”

Orthenon hesitated.

“Some. But most are allowed to leave unharmed, but without any belongings. They mean to starve us, by forcing you to open your storehouses to feed so many.”

“Clever.”

Flos turned away. He stared at the map, and then walked out of the room. Orthenon called out.

“My King? Where are you going?”

“To see these fleeing people for myself. They are frightened, homeless. Because they believed in me. I will go to them. While I do that Orthenon, would you carry out an order?”

“Of course, my King. What is it?”

“Open my storehouses.”

The rest of the day, Trey and Teres stood with Flos as he walked the battlements or descended to the streets, greeting the exhausted people coming to his kingdom.

They came in small groups, some of them. Others arrived in long, winding streams, stumbling towards the gates, footsore, weary. Many had nothing but the clothes on their backs. Some hadn’t eaten in over a day and had to be half-carried inside. But they called out when they saw their King, riding towards them with wagons filled with food.

It was a bad idea to help them. Trey knew that. Teres told him how many storehouses Orthenon had to open and how much was left. And yet,

they were Flos' people and no one in the entire kingdom could have stopped Flos from feeding his subjects or going to them.

They were refugees. People without a home, forced out of their country by war. The very definition of refugees. It surprised Trey, that there would be that kind of people in a fantasy world, a magical one. But that was what made it reality.

Refugees, and dead children. It was too real for Trey.

But still, Flos kept him by his side. And in the evening when the rush of people entering the city had slowed, he took them back to the war room and explained what they were facing.

"It is not a vast army. A large one, yes, but if my kingdom were not wasted from two decades, it would be a poor army to pit against me. As it is, it is the first of many. A test."

It was incredible to Trey that Flos could say that, given the disparity in numbers. But Flos was adamant the coalition wasn't as dangerous as the Emperor of Sands, not by a long shot.

"I am weak. Reim is weak. That is why these small nations have a chance of defeating me, and why they had to declare war now. Eighty thousand soldiers is a force to be reckoned with, but I am a [King] of the highest level, and I have two of my Seven here and Orthenon. Normally any army would hesitate to attack with that knowledge."

"But you're outnumbered *ten to one!*"

Teres pointed that out and Flos nodded.

"We are. But six thousand soldiers to hold a wall is not bad. And there are tricks to be used..."

"I'd feel a lot better if you had a few more zeroes on the end of your army. Like three more zeroes."

Flos had to laugh. He spread his hands over the map as he spoke to the twins.

"Six million? If such an army came towards me I would run long and fast, even if all of my Seven were with me. But sixty thousand is manageable. Perhaps it is a small number to you? The largest of armies I

have seen mustered was over four hundred thousand strong. But it is rare that any one army grows to that size; the logistics of feeding and moving so many grows too extreme. No, when my conquest was at its greatest, I had three armies each over a hundred thousand soldiers in size, and many smaller ones led by my vassals. Is that comparable to your world?”

It was, but not exactly favorably. Trey was hazy on the exact number, but he knew over three million men had served in the British army during World War II. When he told that to Flos, the King’s eyes gleamed.

“Armies of soldiers millions strong. Would that I could see that—but I suppose they would not all be deployed along one single battleground for the same reason. In truth, Trey, Teres, there are armies of that size in this world, only no nation fields them. When a Goblin King rises, his army will be at least a million Goblins strong, and countless more will be led by his Goblin Lords.”

“How do you beat that? How do you beat any army that large?”

“With Skills and levels and a good bit of strategy. Do not worry—I do not rely solely on my Seven and Orthenon when declaring this battle winnable. But it is true they tip the odds greatly by themselves.”

Trey just couldn’t imagine that. One person shouldn’t be able to influence an entire battle, even if they were as strong as Flos. But the King seemed to think each one of his vassals was worth thousands of soldiers.

“Thousands? If used correctly, certainly they could kill thousands. In their own way. Amerys could do it directly with lightning magic. Drevish could probably count the soldiers his walls have killed in the tens or hundreds of thousands.”

“Who were they?”

Trey found the courage to ask that question. Flos blinked at him. Trey found his tongue knotting, but went on when Teres nudged him.

“I mean—sorry, we’ve heard some stories, but no one talks about them. Even Mars and Gazi—people seem to think we should know what they’ve done, but we don’t. What were they like? Mars seems so...normal. Well, sort of. She doesn’t look normal, but—”

Trey yelped as Teres trod on his toe. Flos laughed, but his eyes had turned distant. He went to the map and picked up a small pin with a flag on it.

“What were they like? Ah, Trey. Of all the questions you could ask, that is the hardest. My Seven. You know they were the highest leveled of my vassals, my greatest and most trusted companions?”

Trey and Teres nodded. Trey held his breath as Flos stared down at the map. He seemed older, as he spoke of the past. Older, yet there was a smile on his face when he said their names. And unshed tears in his eyes.

“Mars, Gazi, Takhatres, Drevish, Amerys, Tottenval, and Queravia. Those are the names of my Seven, the heroes who rode with me and shook the world itself.”

Trey hadn’t heard two of those names before. Tottenval and Queravia. He knew without being told they were the two who had died.

Flos went on.

“Not all of them were warriors. Drevish was not, and neither was Tottenval. But they all contributed to my kingdom in some great way. In the past, each of my Seven fulfilled a different purpose. Gazi often rode alone, scouting ahead and behind, safeguarding my kingdom. With her eye and Skills, she slew every [Scout] that sought the movement of my forces, and killed each [Assassin] or [Spy] that dared lurk within my borders.”

“That’s why you sent her out?”

Flos’ eyes met Teres’. He nodded.

“Other nations feared to commit their forces, because they had no clear image of my forces. Some could use magic, but if they sent a person, that person would die within a fortnight. Gazi was feared for her ability to hunt down anyone and find their deepest secrets. When battle called, she would ambush the enemy, infiltrating the camp and killing a valuable soldier or stealing battle plans. Then she would slip away.”

Trey could imagine Gazi doing just that, with her slight smile. That was why she was always looking. That was how she’d found the child. He shivered.

Flos continued.

“Others occupied different roles. Mars is a pure warrior. She would be at the head of every charge, and crush the opposing army’s champion before each battle. She deserved her class. [Vanguard].”

“And Drevish?”

The name made Flos stiffen at first, but then he relaxed. Trey hated to ask. But he wanted to.

“He was an [Architect], right? He built walls, castles, and stuff?”

“More than that. He was one of the three of my Seven who knew magic, Trey. He could enchant a gate so the mightiest battering ram couldn’t break it. He could build a wall overnight with his teams of [Builders], so that an enemy army would be facing a fortified defense when they tried to launch a counterattack. He did not like war. But he was essential. Ah, but I asked too much of him, didn’t I?”

Flos’ head lowered. Trey and Teres exchanged a glance. She was the one who asked the next question.

“What about Orthenon? He’s not one of the Seven, but he’s like them isn’t he?”

“My steward? Yes. He deserves to be placed among them. But he is not *one* of them. He is my left hand, the one who does what I cannot. So he never achieved the same level of fame during the war that they did.”

Flos smiled ruefully. Trey thought about Orthenon carefully and meticulously plotting the enemy’s movements, just like he took care of everything else.

“Is he the one who led your armies? Like a [General], I mean? Or was that you?”

The King looked first surprised, then amused. And then heartbroken.

“Orthenon? No. He was far too busy managing my kingdom to plan out the movement of armies and lead battles himself. I led my own army of course, but I did not have the skill to plan out the grand movements of each of my armies. No, it was another of my Seven who did that. Who...used to do that.”

His fist tightened on the wood. Trey didn't want to ask, but Flos continued. He lowered his head and stared at something neither Trey nor Teres could see.

"Her name was Queravia. She was one of my Seven. She and Tottenval died in the war. She led my armies, not Orthenon. It was she who won the fiercest battles in my name, directing soldiers while my other vassals rode forth and fought on the front lines."

He had to ask it. Trey whispered.

"What was her class?"

The wood on the war room table *cracked* slightly. Then Flos looked up and smiled. Tears ran down into his beard.

"She was a [Strategist]. The finest in the world."

His smile slipped.

"Second finest. No. No—she was the greatest of them all!"

He seemed to be arguing with himself. Flos turned his face to Trey, and there was pain in his eyes.

"I did not see her end. But I heard of it. I did not think it was possible that she would ever die. She was my great strategist, Trey. Not just any [Strategist] either—she bet against luck itself. She was a gambler, a [Gambler Strategist]. Before she died she was a [Gambler of Fates]. And she lost her last bet in Baleros."

There were no more questions after that. Flos wept and the twins left the room, shaken, hearing the past echo around the King of Destruction. They knew him well, after having lived and heard his more secret confidences for a month. And yet, they knew him not at all. They did not know what he had lost.

In the days that followed, things went simply for Trey and Teres. They followed, they watched, they saw streams of refugees fleeing the enemy

army, and they heard endless reports about it approaching.

Gazi returned after two days, riding hard, looking tired. But she had come with vital news.

“Sixty-two thousand strong.”

Orthenon bent over the map, looking tired. He had good news for Flos and a lot of bad news.

“There are less mages than we could hope for in their number, and Lady Gazi reports that none of them are of the highest level each nation could offer.”

“They’re being cautious. No one wants to commit all of their best.”

Gazi sat gulping water in a chair. She eyed a plate of biscuits that had been prepared for the meeting in the war room, but didn’t take one. Trey didn’t either; he knew they’d go to people who were actually hungry afterwards.

“Less mages is good news. Without Amerys, we lack any magic users of note. What is the bad news?”

Orthenon grimaced.

“They’ve brought siege weapons. Even a pair of trebuchets.”

Mars swore. Trey looked around. Flos had to explain.

“Siege weapons are not common for most armies. They are hard to produce, and only rare classes such as [Engineer] can create them. However, they are manageable in battle...”

“But not what we want in a siege.”

Orthenon nodded. He stared out of the window at one of the battlements. Trey knew that the city had a number of high watch towers and decently tall walls, but no trebuchets or catapults of their own.

“Drevish worked on the city, but he only did so once. And that was before we formed an alliance with the Mad Ones. He never installed siege fortifications for defense.”

“And if he had, no doubt they would have rotted away by now. That complicates the issue.”

Flos nodded. He still didn't look concerned, but perhaps that was because he was a King and couldn't afford to show weakness. Trey could do that for the both of them. His heart was pounding out of his chest.

"I think we had better rely on the original plan. In which case, we must sortie and meet the army in the field, rather than wait for them to assail us with their siege weapons."

Orthenon began placing units outside of the city. Flos nodded. Trey, who hadn't been privy to every discussion, stared blankly at the board. Orthenon was taking half of the soldiers out of the city? Three thousand versus sixty thousand sounded a lot worse, and Trey had thought it was impossible to make the odds any more stacked against them.

"In that case, I will take all of our mounted forces, a good number of our highest level foot—a unit of archers under Lady Maresar, and Lady Gazi. Our plan will be aided by some of Gazi's acquisitions from her adventuring days."

"Oh?"

Gazi grinned.

"Fog arrows. I bought a quiver back when I was going through one of the Walled Cities."

"Fog arrows? Now that changes things. I assume they're mine to use?"

Maresar broke into the conversation, looking intrigued. Gazi smiled, and they walked to a corner to talk with unsettling grins. Trey saw Orthenon glance several times at his King before he cleared his throat.

"This plan will necessitate you staying behind in the city, my King."

Flos' brows snapped together.

"And leave you to face that army alone?"

"We *cannot* execute our plan if you are with us, my King. The coalition army is here for only one reason. Your head. And we must keep the city secure or else lose it while half of our army is in the field."

"Your plan is dangerous, Orthenon. I cannot sit idly by—I will ride with you. My Skills will make this part of your plan—"

“We need them at a later point, my King! You must wait. You *must*—”

Flos began arguing hotly with Orthenon. Meanwhile, Trey and Teres stared at the map. Teres nudged Trey.

“What’s the plan?”

“I don’t know! Did they come up with it when we weren’t there?”

“Maybe yesterday? When we went to lunch?”

They were so busy whispering, they didn’t notice Mars coming up behind them. She slung an arm around both twin’s shoulders.

“Hey. You two. Explain the plan to me.”

They stared at her. Mars stared back.

“Come on, you’re always hanging around our King.”

“We don’t know.”

“Aw. You two don’t?”

“We know they’re taking half of their forces—the fastest out to fight. Flos—uh, the King will stay here. And Gazi’s got fog arrows.”

“Does she? Okay...that could be useful. But why aren’t we all going out at once?”

“I don’t know. What do you think?”

Mars stared down at the map. Her brows furrowed. She eyed the enemy army, Orthenon’s proposed force. She blinked.

“I don’t get it.”

She’d spoken a bit too loudly. Every head turned towards Mars. She flushed red. Orthenon turned back to Flos and the others as if she hadn’t interrupted.

“You must stay here, my King.”

“I suppose I must, mustn’t I?”

Flos clenched his fists as he stared at the map. He sighed, looking tired.

“Very well, Orthenon. We shall go with your plan. But only if our inspection shows an adequate charge. Understand?”

Orthenon nodded. Then he turned to Mars. She was busy telling the twins about fog arrows, which wasn't helpful. Because what they did was apparently create fog. Lots of fog.

"Lady Mars, it would be best if you stayed with our King in case more assassins are sent in great numbers. You must guard the city while we are in the field."

"What?"

Mars stared incredulously at Orthenon. Trey and Teres stared too. They had been under the impression that Mars was great at fighting—better than Orthenon or Gazi. Mars glared at Orthenon.

"Don't be an idiot! You need me out there! Against seventy thousand —"

"We need you to guard our King more. This initial part of the plan will work without you, and I will not leave our King without at least one of our number in case the enemy splits their forces."

Orthenon stared at Mars. Gazi turned and grinned at the [Vanguard].

"And you wouldn't be able to keep up with us for what we need to do. Sorry."

Mars argued. She raged. She turned over chairs. But Flos told her she had to stay, and that was that.

And afterwards, when the meeting was over and everyone split up, Mars sat in a chair and sulked. This came as a surprise to Trey, since everyone else was busy. Gazi was scouting the terrain, Maresar was drilling soldiers and Orthenon was managing everything else. Flos was inspecting the battlements, but Mars was sitting where she was. Doing nothing.

Now that he thought about it, Trey hadn't seen Mars doing anything these last few days either. He asked Orthenon about it as the man strode out of the war room. It was the first time Trey had ever seen the steward's pained expression as he tried to explain Mars' role in the kingdom to the young man.

"Mars is...competent. In battle. However, outside of it she is best suited to training and..."

He paused. Orthenon opened his mouth and searched for words. Then he gave up.

“Well, her presence may inspire others. But she is best utilized at this moment sitting and...”

“Not getting in the way.”

Gazi put that in. Maresar nodded as she broke off from them. Trey stared at Flos’ vassals, and then at Flos. The King looked sheepish.

“Of her talents...talent...well, Mars is suited for war, Trey. One part of it. Fighting. At other matters, she is somewhat lacking. But then, if we were all like her...”

He had trouble finishing that thought. In the end, he just took Trey and Teres on a tour of the battlements, inspecting them for Orthenon’s plan. What they were looking at, Trey didn’t know. But Flos was happy to lecture them on the walls.

“They aren’t very tall, you see. Drevish could only work with the existing stone so much, and he had no desire to completely remodel the city.”

“He didn’t? I thought he worked on the city a lot.”

Teres looked at Flos. The King laughed heartily.

“Hah! He spent the least amount of time on Reim than any of his projects! If you compared this city to any of the ones he constructed from scratch, I think he’d have a heart attack. Or try to kill you. Or both. Drevish *hated* this city. Note how the walls are merely thirty feet high, without any additions to the fortifications? Drevish would never have constructed such mundane defenses.”

“So he didn’t work on the city is what you’re saying.”

Trey’s estimation of their odds of success went down another notch. Flos shook his head.

“He worked on the city, and my palace. But he made only one major improvement. No, you see, Drevish disliked remodeling existing architecture. He was far more interested in Drake construction practices

than the Chandrarian style on that note. He especially disliked the way the towers are placed, although he did work extensively with them.”

“How do you mean?”

Trey had seen the watch towers. There were sixteen of them, placed at equal distances along the curtain wall. They were very big and could hold a lot of archers on top. Flos pointed to each of them.

“Drevish considered them aesthetically disgusting. See how they jut out? And if you look at the wall, what does it remind you of?”

Trey had to think for only a second.

“A crown.”

Flos nodded, smiling at the recollection.

“All that work just to create a crown, which is rather spoiled by the palace in the center. Drevish told me my city was an eyesore that ought to be wiped from the face of the earth. But he did like the height of the towers. He believed in what he called self-sufficient architecture, buildings that didn’t need to be protected, that were capable of protecting themselves.”

“Like how?”

“Well...these towers would normally carry high-level archers and mages that could rain death upon an enemy. They’re enchanted quite heavily, and Amerys aided in that. But Drevish once made what he called a sniper tower. It was over a hundred feet tall, and so enchanted a trebuchet couldn’t knock it down. He claimed that if you put an archer in there—only one!—they could hold it forever with enough food. There were no entrances leading up, you see, and if they used the cover of the walls, they could shoot down enemy mages and so on.”

“That sounds...really interesting.”

Flos nodded. He stared at one of the towers and sighed, suddenly melancholy.

“He did work hard on this city, for all it was anathema to him. I wish I could say his work has stood the test of time, but six of the towers have worn away over the decades. Still, I think there is enough to complete

Orthenon's plan. A pity Amerys is not here. She could have restored the enchantments."

"And just what is the plan?"

Flos just grinned at Trey. He put a finger over his lips.

"Orthenon has bade me not to speak of it in public. But it is a good plan. And it is...appropriate. You see, my city has never been besieged."

"What, never?"

"I was always on the offensive. And by the time other nations formed armies to attack, well, Reim sat at the heart of my empire. My bastion. So I have never had to defend it. This time will be the first. And perhaps—last."

He patted the wall of one of the watch towers fondly, staring up at the dark peak. Trey felt another lurch of fear in his stomach, but Flos' eyes were calm. He smiled.

"Yes, but how appropriate it is. Drevish, old friend. Even in death you protect me."

Then he turned, and strode away. Trey stared up at the towers. They stood tall and black in the night sky.

Waiting.

And then it was time. Trey nearly choked on his food when Orthenon came striding into the banquet hall, dressed for war. He was wearing leather armor and there was a sword at his waist. He strode up to the table where Flos was sitting down to eat for once. The King looked up and pushed his plate back.

"It is time?"

"The army is a day's march away. We will meet them halfway and begin the plan."

Orthenon stepped forwards as Flos rose. The [King] and his steward clasped hands. Flos looked Orthenon in the eye.

“Go with my heart, Orthenon. It rides with you. Come back alive. You too, Gazi.”

The half-Gazer was wearing her brown scale armor. She reached up to clasp Flos’ hands. There was a slight smile on Orthenon’s face.

“I would hardly let myself get killed on the first battle since you awoke, my King. We shall return soon enough. Be ready for us.”

“We shall throw open the gates! Ride forth, and remind these foolish nations what it is to challenge me!”

Flos roared and the people in the banquet hall leapt to their feet. Orthenon and Gazi strode out of the hall, Flos and a stream of people following. There was already an army at the gates, mainly mounted warriors on horses. Trey stared at them through a window, and then turned.

Mars was sitting at a table, hunched over, clearly miserable that she had to stay. She met Trey’s eyes and lifted a mug.

“Here’s to not being able to ride a damn horse as fast as those two! And not being able to fight on horseback at all!”

She hurled her mug as Orthenon, Gazi, Lady Maresar, and four thousand of Flos’ soldiers rode out to meet over sixty thousand soldiers in battle.

The minutes after Orthenon had left seemed to drag on like hours to Trey and to Teres. She’d said goodbye to Orthenon at the gates, upon which she’d burst into tears and refused to speak to Trey. She was carrying Orthenon’s sword around—Trey had a steel sword Flos had given him personally. He felt like he shouldn’t have been wearing it, but he was too afraid to take it off.

“Don’t let your mind dwell on it. Orthenon will be riding for hours before he meets the enemy. And it will be later still that we hear any word on whether the plan is succeeding.”

Flos warned the twins. He seemed hardly able to take his own advice. He was pacing around his throne room, unable to sit still. He'd gone to the balcony twice, as if to stare at the distant patch of horizon where Orthenon and Gazi had last been spotted, when someone rushed into the throne room.

“My King!”

It was a servant, one of Orthenon's aides, panting, almost out of breath. She could barely explain to Flos what was the matter, so he followed her out of the throne room at a run. Trey and Teres caught up outside the palace, at the western gates, to see...

Blood. Staggering bodies. A man without an arm, holding bloody rags that might have been a body. Someone without an eye. A girl with an arrow protruding from her side.

People were coming through the gates, many wounded. Trey stared in horror at a wailing baby being held by a man who was trying not to let the blood spilling from his arm fall on the child. He wavered and would have fallen, but Flos caught him.

“Get me every [Healer] in the city! Now!”

He shouted as he held a hand over the cut in the man's arm, stopping the bleeding. The man sagged as Teres took the baby out of his limp arms. He stared up at his King and recognized him. He smiled.

And died.

Somewhere between people rushing towards the wounded with bandages and Flos shouting, the news came out. There were more refugees, being herded from other countries. They'd been on the road for days, thousands, maybe tens of thousands of them. But soldiers had ridden down on them in the final stretch. They were cutting everyone they saw apart. Mounted soldiers, maybe only a hundred of them. Maybe a lot more.

It was impossible to tell. They were killing everything. It was just blood and death out there.

Flos stared towards the west, where more groups of shapes were approaching down the road. Trey shakily held a man's arm with Teres as a [Healer] tried to wind bandages around a cut in his stomach. He was screaming and thrashing, but Flos didn't turn his head.

“I must go.”

“What?”

Mars was there, in full armor. She was staring at the refugees with a sick expression on her face. She stared at Flos as he turned.

“Saddle my horse. I am going out there.”

“My lord, you *cannot*—”

Mars grabbed for Flos’ arm. He stared at her.

“My people are dying out there.”

“There is an *army* approaching! Send some soldiers—”

“I cannot send a force large enough to catch a hundred mounted riders. But I can rally my people. You know I can, Mars.”

She shook her head, sending her perfect red curls flying.

“Let me go instead! I can do it—”

“You cannot catch a mounted force, Mars! No, I must go. You must stay here and—”

“No!”

“You must! Someone of high level has to hold these walls. It can only be you.”

“I cannot let you risk your life—”

Trey was holding the wounded man’s arm as tightly as possible. It was that or be thrown off, even with Teres helping him. At some point she shook him, and told him he could let go. Trey realized the shaking had stopped.

The man was dead.

Flos turned to look as Trey got up, shaking, blood on his arms and legs. He looked at Mars, and it was a [King] who spoke next.

“Mars. I must go. Guard the city for me.”

She could not disobey. Trey saw her try. Mars’ mouth opened, and her arms and legs shook. She tried to move as Flos strode away, and then slumped.

He didn't know why he did it. But Trey ran after Flos, and Teres was there too. They caught him as he was mounting his warhorse. Flos turned to look at them.

"Will you come with me? It is dangerous."

"Yes."

Trey and Teres didn't know why they said it. Neither of them were warriors. They hadn't been trained. But they knew they had to follow. It wasn't Flos commanding them. It was something in them, something that wanted to follow this King. To see.

Flos didn't argue. He just called for two more horses and in minutes the twins were mounted. He said only one word.

"Follow."

They rode out of the city at a gallop. Trey thought he heard people screaming Flos' name, but their voices were left behind in an instant. Then Flos and the twins were riding along the dirt road, passing by people, wounded people, who looked up and saw their King.

It was a trap. Of course it was. The King knew it was. But Nune Salismen knew the King of Destruction would enter the trap. Because that was the nature of [Kings]. That was his nature.

He had studied Flos, learned all there was to know about the man when he had been given his orders by Queen Calliope. So it was with satisfaction that Nune heard out the [Scout]'s report as the rider found his hidden encampment in the hills.

"The King has left his city. He is undefended, save for the fleeing civilians and two children."

Nune nodded and ordered the camp struck. His men jumped to work with alacrity. They had been waiting for this moment. There was exaltation in Nune's heart. His plan was working!

But there was fear as well. It was really happening. The King of Destruction would die today. Today. At the hands of a force led by Nune. Nune. Not a [General], but a [Commander]. The King of Destruction would die in an ambush as he rode to save his people from a handful of raiding soldiers.

But it wasn't a hundred men that Nune had brought. Not even close. He had just under eight hundred soldiers, the largest force he could sneak close to Reim, even with Gazi the Omniscient blinded. Perhaps that might not have been enough, though. Irrational as it was, Nune wondered if a thousand men could slay the King of Destruction. But Nune had another advantage on his side.

He approached the only tent that stood out from the dark grey uniformity of his camp. A bright yellow tent—totally inappropriate for an ambush—housed the one man not directly under Nune's command. He emerged as Nune waited by the tent flap.

"The King has fallen into your trap?"

"As I said. We are ready to march. My men will cut the route back to Reim off and then we will attack. Are you ready?"

The [Mage] smiled thinly. He had multiple rings to each finger, and he held a glowing staff with a crystal orb floating above the wood shaft. He was the very stereotype of a [Mage], and most would have considered him all show and no substance. But Nune knew the façade was there for that very reason.

"I am grateful for your assistance. Slaying the King might not have been possible without your aid."

The [Mage] inclined his head, politely accepting Nune's words.

"It is my honor as well. And my duty. I have a message the Quarass bid me deliver to the King of Destruction."

Nune paused. This was the first time he'd heard of that.

"What is the message?"

The [Mage] smiled. He tapped the ground with his staff, and the earth shook. Nune stared into two innocuous, watery brown eyes. You would never have thought they were the eyes of a Level 36 [Geomancer].

“His death.”

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Venith heard the messenger out in silence. His teeth ground together and the mounted soldiers watched him cautiously. They were eighteen, and though Venith's own soldiers were present in the courtyard, they would have the advantage in the seconds following.

But Venith Crusland had a hand on his sword. He gripped it with knuckles that slowly turned white as he glared at the man who had delivered the demand.

"This was not what I agreed to."

"Your oath was to prevent the King of Destruction's return. All you must do is stand aside."

Venith heard something *crack* as his grip tightened even further on his sword's hilt. He relaxed his grip slightly. Too much strength would dull his thrusts. If it came to that.

"Those are *my* subjects you intend to slaughter out there!"

"They abandoned you, did they not?"

It was true. They had left. So had Mares. His *wife*. The very thought made Venith want to lash out, but he couldn't. The soldiers standing before him had come in peace, and offered no insult he could claim. And he had sworn an oath.

Even so.

"It is not honorable. If you want to kill Flos, take your army and lay siege to his capital. Using tricks is the act of a coward."

The messenger's face didn't change, nor did those of the soldiers behind them. Venith knew his words had little sting to them. They were from Hellios, and their hatred of the King of Destruction ran deep.

"It is one plan. If it fails, the coalition army will crush Flos and burn Reim to the ground. But it would be simpler if his head could be taken before so many lives are lost. Is that not the best result?"

It might have been. But Venith's soul revolted at the thought.

“It is not *honorable*.”

The mounted man’s face twisted in annoyance. He snapped down at Venith.

“Honorable or not, all you must do is not interfere. If your patrols had not clashed with ours, we would not be having this conversation!”

“Had you decided to avoid cutting through my lands, I wouldn’t have paid attention. But even a small army is my business. And your forces didn’t cover their tracks well enough. They were sloppy.”

Venith relished the flash of anger in the man’s eyes. But the messenger controlled himself. He shook his head coldly.

“You have sworn an oath, Venith Crusland. Your wife, Lady Maresar —”

He paused. Venith’s blade had inched out a bit from his scabbard. The men tensed. The messenger continued, choosing his words carefully.

“Your subjects have renounced their homes and joined the King of Destruction. But you fought and attempted to uphold your oath. The kingdoms see you as an ally, which is why your lands have been spared.”

Ally? The word was insulting. The other kingdoms saw Venith as someone they could ignore. They didn’t need to waste men on him if they could just let him be.

“This ambush will fail. All it will do is slay more innocent lives. Those refugees are not soldiers.”

“One day they might be. It has already begun. Do not interfere.”

The messenger was tired of the argument. He wheeled his mount. The escort followed him, keeping together, watching Venith’s soldiers warily.

Now would be the time. To stop them, to call out their dishonorable actions and fight. Venith knew it. He felt the blood pumping through his veins. His hand was on his sword.

He let them go.

Half an hour later, Venith was in his war room. It was just a small cubicle in his keep really, a place for him to survey the terrain. It wasn't as if he had ridden to war since he had taken his oath against his former King. All he had ever done was slay the occasional monster or crush a group of bandits.

Now Venith stared at a map covered with small flags. A vast army was on the march, to the north east, winding down the long road towards Reim. But his eyes were on the patch of land to the west of the capital, where a second road led to other crossroads and kingdoms.

There were more flags there. Venith could only guess the ambushing force's location, but there were only so many places they could hide. They were camped in the foothills, waiting for the King of Destruction to ride out to save the refugees being attacked by raiders. They would swoop down on him and encircle his position.

And kill him. It was a sensible measure. Without him, his kingdom would fall apart, despite Orthenon, Mars, and Gazi. But it was not honorable. Those butchers would kill hundreds of men, women and children just to kill a single King.

But Venith had sworn an oath to do just that. So he could not do anything about it.

Venith had a cool drink of grape wine from his cellars. He was not thirsty, but the thought of drinking himself into a stupor was enticing. He had never done it, but now—

The door to his small war room opened. Venith turned, about to curtly dismiss whoever had opened the door and paused.

“Calac.”

His son stood in the doorway, armed for war. The plate armor had to be hot in the sun's rays, but Venith had ordered every man and woman to ready themselves for battle when he'd seen the armed force approaching. He wondered why Calac hadn't taken off his armor yet.

“What's the matter, son? Is there news?”

“No news. Nothing's happening here. The soldiers are leaving.”

Calac's face was blank. He stared at his father, eyes searching Venith's face. Then he shifted his attention to the map. He looked at Venith.

"Is this the kind of man you are?"

Something about his tone made Venith angry. It was insubordinate, the prelude to a fight. He glared at his son. But Calac didn't flinch.

"What is that supposed to mean?"

"You heard what they're going to do. They're going to kill the King of Destruction. Lure him out by killing innocent people. And you didn't stop them."

The words twisted into Venith's heart. He turned away roughly, staring down at the map.

"So? I swore an oath—"

"Is that the kind of man you are? The kind of man who hides behind oaths when injustice is done?"

Those words. Venith spun. He hurled something—the cup of wine. Calac flinched as the liquid sprayed across his face and armor. But he didn't back down.

"*I swore an oath.* Are you suggesting I break it? I have never gone back on my word, never lied. That is the kind of man I am!"

He snarled at his only son. But Calac just wiped away dripping wine from his face.

"So it's fine if everyone else breaks their oath, just not you? That man—Hellios is sending an army out to kill *our people*. If they're on the road, they'll die. They'd dishonor themselves and break the rules of war just to kill the King of Destruction. And what happens if he dies? Does that mean mother and everyone else get slaughtered too?"

"It won't come to that. They'll lay down their arms."

Venith felt the words twist in his mouth. Calac made a sound that wasn't a laugh.

"Mother? Never."

That was true too. It was true. But Venith had—he clenched his fists.

“The King of Des—Flos broke his oath long ago. I owe him nothing.”

“You told me that all my life. Every time mother told me about him, you’d always say he was a fool. An oathbreaker. A coward who abandoned his kingdom. And I believed you. I thought he didn’t have a shred of pride or honor.”

Calac’s voice was quiet. He stared at his father.

“But now I see the truth. These kingdoms, and these other [Rulers] have no honor either. Less. At least the King of Destruction was willing to fight his own battle. And he spared you.”

“I was prepared to die. I did not ask him for mercy.”

Venith wanted his son to shout back at him, to make it an argument—but Calac’s voice was level. It wasn’t angry; there was too much of his mother’s voice, Mares’ voice in the way he spoke.

“I admire my father. The man who raised me taught me how to be honorable, to keep my word. He taught me to defend the innocent and never bow to injustice. He taught me to do what was *right*.”

Arrows at his heart. Venith’s voice rose and he shouted at his son.

“Not to obey orders, apparently! You disgraced yourself in battle not a day ago!”

It was a petty thing to say. Calac’s head lowered, and then he looked up at his father.

“I did. I thought I could end things easily, even if it meant being dishonorable. That was the wrong thing to do, wasn’t it?”

“Yes. It was dishonorable. There is no excuse for such actions, regardless of the reason.”

Finally, something Venith could say with conviction. Calac nodded slowly.

“Then why are you lecturing me and not stopping those men?”

Silence. Venith searched for words, and found none. Calac turned.

“I’m going. Me and some of the soldiers are going to ride to the King of Destruction’s side. We’ll probably die, but at least we’ll die doing the right

thing. Like you taught me.”

“You *cannot*—you’d abandon your post?”

Venith forced the words out, a gasp through his suddenly tight chest. Calac nodded.

“It’s the right thing to do, father. Mom was right.”

“Then you’re a traitor too! You—abandoning your home, your people!”

“What people, father? What home? There’s just you here, and some soldiers. Everyone is with the King of Destruction. Flos. Mother’s King. Our King. Your King.”

Calac turned and began walking down the narrow corridors of the keep. Venith stumbled after him. He felt drunk, disoriented. He shouted at his son’s back.

“You swore to obey my orders! Come back!”

For a second, Calac turned. He stared at his father and Venith felt a surge of hope. But then he spoke.

“I’m sorry. You taught me how to be proud, how to keep my word. How to be honorable. But father, I guess I never learned what loyalty meant.”

Then he turned and walked away. Leaving Venith with nothing at all.

The air was hot. Uleth, the [General] leading the coalition army of six nations, stared ahead at the small army barring their way.

“Not even five thousand soldiers? Is the King of Destruction mad?”

“Drunk on his own fame, perhaps. But he’s not even with this army, so perhaps it’s his [Steward] who’s made the decision.”

One of the strategists from Germina commented as he squinted at the army ahead of Uleth’s forces. Uleth shook his head.

“I’ve studied the battle tactics used by Orthenon. He’s no fool. Regardless of their reasons, they’ve come to us. Ready yourselves! I want

[Mages] and [Archers] to begin firing as soon as they come within range!”

“And the formation?”

The [Strategist] frowned. Uleth glared at him.

“As I ordered.”

The man hesitated, which annoyed Uleth. But he wasn’t one of Uleth’s subordinates. The [General] wouldn’t have worked with him at all, save for his level. But the orders were passed down and Uleth saw his forces begin to rearrange themselves out of the long column they’d been marching in.

The [General] had a Skill. [Battlefield Eye]. It allowed Uleth to see, or rather, create an image of the battlefield from any angle based on his own line of sight and the reports he received. With it, he saw his army spreading out, encircling his position while his mages and the siege weapons he’d brought moved into the center.

They weren’t all bunched up in the center; that was an invitation for a mage strike, and Uleth wasn’t about to risk it, for all that Flos wasn’t supposed to have any strong mages in the field. Rather, his valuable units such as [Mages] and the two trebuchets were scattered around him, buffered by soldiers. At the center of what was a giant ellipse of soldiers lay Uleth’s command and the [General] himself. From there he could issue any order and the dozens of [Tacticians] and [Strategists] he’d brought could assume command of individual groups of soldiers.

Uleth knew it was not an orthodox formation. He didn’t care. Against an army of equal size, his deployment would leave him understrength if the enemy committed to any one side. But he was up against an army a fraction of his size.

“The instant the enemy comes within range, bombard them. When they attack, we will seal their exits with cavalry and envelop them.”

He repeated the plan to his gathered officers, making sure they could move even without orders. Uleth had [Sergeants], [Captains], and so forth, but his [Strategists] could provide incredible benefits to a battalion by using their Skills at the right moment.

That was what would tip the scales here. Not grand strategy but Skills. Uleth knew he was outmatched in terms of levels by Orthenon, known far

and wide as the King of Destruction's Left Hand. But he was only one leader. Uleth had brought dozens to match him.

And he had the numbers on his side. So many it wasn't a fair battle, however many of the King's Seven were on the field. Uleth kept repeating that to himself. His plan was solid. Overwhelm with sheer numbers. So long as Uleth kept his most valuable assets shielded by his soldiers, he would triumph, regardless of the King of Destruction's superior individual might.

But the army of four thousand wasn't moving. Uleth squinted at them. He could have had a [Mage] use a spell to enhance his sight, but they were visible in the distance. A good deal of cavalry; far fewer foot soldiers than Uleth had expected. Were some defending the city? Why? Why split up forces?

They weren't moving. That wasn't what Uleth expected of Orthenon. The man should have launched a surprise attack while Uleth's army was on the move. Fast, lightning strikes were what he was known for. Why was he —

Someone blew a horn. A warning. Uleth saw a distant figure move in Orthenon's army, but saw nothing happen. He turned to the [Strategist] from Germina.

"What's happening?"

"Someone's firing an arrow."

The man had a Skill and he was shading his eyes to see. His gaze traced the flight of the arrow—Uleth, watching, saw only a blur and then heard a scream.

"A lone archer? Are they targeting someone?"

"No—they didn't aim at any of our [Mages]."

"Well then, send a volley back! Have our highest-level [Archers]—"

"Look!"

The man cried out. Uleth turned and saw fog. It was billowing up. *Fog*. Despite the harsh sunlight, it rose out of the ground to the surprised shouts of the soldiers. From where the arrow had landed.

"More arrows!"

They were falling amid Uleth's army, releasing fog which obscured all vision. Uleth gritted his teeth. He turned his head and roared.

"[Mages]! Lift the fog!"

For a few minutes he heard no response. Then one of his messengers ran towards him.

"The [Mages] are attempting to lift the fog, but it will take them several minutes! The arrows are high-Tier magic—"

"Attack!"

Someone shouted it. Uleth's head turned as he heard the horn calls from the side. They were unmistakable.

"The army has charged us in the fog! They're engaged with our left flank!"

"I will move our forces out to engage—"

"No!"

Uleth stopped everyone with a word. He stood still, heart pounding. But he was certain.

"Do not move. Let Orthenon attack. He is attempting to force us to break formation. But we will hold position."

"[General], the casualties—"

"We will hold position until the [Mages] lift the fog. Even if Orthenon charges his army, he will only be fighting a fraction of this army. When the air clears we will encircle him and destroy his army. You, you, you—go and reinforce the battle zone. Everyone else will *hold position*."

There was no argument on the battlefield. Not with the [General]. Uleth saw men and women running and waited. Minutes until the mists cleared. All he had to do was wait. Orthenon was famous for mind-games, for striking an enemy's weak spot when they reacted to his provocations. All he had to do was wait—

The sound of clashing arms was distant, and Uleth could hear shouts, screams, horn calls in the distance. He fancied he could even smell the blood pouring already, metallic. Sharp.

But then he heard something. It wasn't loud, but it was deep. So deep it cut below the sounds in the distance. Uleth began to rub at his ears.

"What's making that sound?"

He turned his head, but could barely see his command, let alone the soldiers in the dense fog. He could see faint shapes in the mist, but they turned into shadows and then nothing. But the sound continued.

"I said, what in the name of sands is—"

And then it grew louder and Uleth realized what it was.

Humming.

Ahead of Uleth, the fog parted. A slim silhouette emerged from the white oblivion. A stranger holding a huge sword in one hand. She walked forwards, humming that haunting melody under her breath.

Dark shadows ran towards her, and Uleth heard the voices of men and women shouting. The figure swung her sword. Shadows fell to the ground. She walked on.

"Enemy attack!"

Someone shouted. But more voices were yelling the same thing. And the soldiers weren't moving. They couldn't *see* in the fog and they were a force of many nations. If they rushed to attack, they might find themselves locked in combat with their own forces.

Some were. Uleth heard the clash of arms *behind* him, where no one was attacking. But he only had eyes for the advancing shape. No one could see in this damned fog. No one. Except perhaps someone who had earned her title for doing just that.

Uleth felt a chill. He knew she was on the battlefield. He knew she was here. But it was one thing to hear of her, and another to see her. He whispered her name.

"Gazi the Omniscient."

The half-Gazer walked into view. Her sword was red. Her armor was dyed crimson. Her central, main eye was closed, but all four of her smaller eyes were focused on him. On Uleth.

He drew his sword. His command formed up, [Tacticians] shouting, Uleth's elite soldiers forming a wall between him and one of the King's Seven. Two [Mages] strode forwards, grasping wands nervously. They were all staring at Gazi.

She could not hope to kill them all herself. Uleth's mind babbled it as he froze, trying to think of orders. But all he could remember were the tales of entire commands slain in the middle of battle, of night ambushes that left no one alive.

"Ch—char—"

His men were staring at him. But Uleth couldn't form the words properly. How had she come here? They were at the heart of his army! She would have had to cut her way through all those soldiers? Alone?

And then Uleth heard galloping horses and more screams. He saw a second figure appear out of the fog. A man on horseback, a spear in hand. More shapes broke out of the mist behind him. Mounted soldiers. They had cut their way through the stationary troops, led by the leader of the army himself.

Orthenon. Uleth stared at him. The King's [Steward] raised his spear, and Uleth tried to make his mouth work.

"Char—"

"Charge!"

The King's [Steward] kicked his horse forwards, and his entire army, cavalry and screaming soldiers, rushed out of the fog straight towards Uleth.

There was a war going on. Trey knew he should be hiding in the city of Reim, away from it. He was no soldier, no fighter. He could barely use a sword. But he rode across the barren ground, following a King.

Flos rode like the wind. No—the wind was weightless. In that case, Flos rode like thunder. He was mounted, riding hard and fast down the road, past

groups of people.

And bodies. Some were collapsed, bundles of rags on first glance, until you saw the blood. They flashed past Trey, but he could smell the death as he passed.

And then he saw the people on horseback. He must have turned past a mound of dirt or else there was some gradient to the landscape, because there they were. Trey saw it in a flash. A huge crowd of screaming people fleeing. A knot of armed men and women—barely armored. Flashing swords, and the riders breaking away from the fighting to ride down on some of the fleeing refugees.

They barely saw Flos before it was too late. A man wearing scale armor and holding a spear was riding towards a young woman who'd fallen. He raised the spear, and his head turned as he spotted Flos, riding towards him.

He tried to turn his horse. But too slow. Flos' sword cut up, through the man's armpit. The arm holding the spear fell; the second cut went halfway through the man's neck, between the gap of helmet and armor.

Flos yanked his sword away as the man fell. He turned and rode at the other riders without pausing. They paused, uncertain. Then they recognized him. The King of Destruction.

Some tried to flee. Flos rode down on a slimmer shape on horseback. A female warrior? His sword flashed and one of the riders fell, headless. Flos turned and his sword shot out, stabbing at another rider's chest.

The man or woman blocked, but the thrust carried them out of the saddle. Flos rode his mount forwards and trampled the fallen rider as he cut at the third man on horseback as he rode at Flos, curved scimitar raised, screaming.

The man was wearing armor, but Flos' blow knocked his sword aside and smashed into the pauldron the man was wearing. The armor bent around the blow. So did flesh and bone. Trey heard the man cry out in agony. He died reaching for his crushed shoulder as Flos' second blow crushed his skull and helmet.

Seconds. Trey was still riding towards the dead rider as the last toppled from his horse when he realized he was riding straight into the battle. He

pulled desperately at his horse's reins and the horse reared.

Trey had to clutch desperately at the horse to keep from falling off. He heard someone shout his name.

"Trey!"

His sister rode past him, only managing to slow her horse after several more yards. She turned and he saw she'd drawn her sword.

"Don't—"

He reached for her. Trey couldn't have said why. He just knew he couldn't let his sister, Teres, ride into the heart of that battle. She stared at him, and then turned her head.

There was no need for Teres. Flos was enough. He rode at the group of fighting men and women, aimed straight at the attackers on horseback. They too saw him too late.

It was like a red whirlwind. Flos' sword moved in flashes, each time slicing through skin, bone, and even armor, or crushing the very same. There were two dozen mounted soldiers—Flos rode into them from behind and they began falling from their saddles. In pieces.

Trey saw the blood. He saw people dying, in ways he couldn't have dreamed of. He saw a man raise a shield and Flos' blow split his helm and expose his shattered skull.

Trey leaned over and threw up on the ground. That felt appropriate. There wasn't any glory in this, any excitement.

But there was vengeance. And there was hope, when the fleeing people and those who had tried to fight looked up and saw their King, holding his bloody sword in the air.

"My King!"

The twins couldn't bring themselves to ride towards the carnage, but Flos rode back towards them. Trey flinched when he saw the blood spattered along his arm and chest. Flos just looked at him and nodded.

"This is my world. See it with your own two eyes."

Then he turned to the people who were flocking around him. They shouted his name.

“My King!”

“Our King has come to save us!”

“Long live Flos!”

Flos said one word.

“*Silence.*”

And there was. He turned to one of the few refugees holding a weapon. Trey was surprised to see it was a balding man, hair white and wispy, with a wide hat on his head. He didn’t look like a warrior, but there was blood on the short axe he carried, and none on his body.

“You. Tell me what is happening.”

This man wasn’t weeping. He stared up at Flos with a huge, face-splitting grin. He bowed his head, but spoke clearly.

“My King. I don’t know how many of ‘em are out there, but there’s dozens of these fiends chopping anyone on the road to bits. We were marching when they came out of the blue, like. We tried to fend them off, but they were choppin’ us to bits before you charged into them.”

Flos nodded. His eyes found the other people holding weapons. They were all older men and women, Trey saw. Some were *much* older. Grandparents. An elderly woman had a shortbow in one hand. But what was surprising was how natural it seemed in her grip.

“There are elite warriors among you. Few, but I see it. I know *you*, don’t I?”

The man looked startled and then grinned, exposing a few teeth.

“I was an [Axe Guard], a [Sergeant] in your army, my King! I retired after you went into slumber, but I kept my levels and my axe.”

“I remember you. I remember not your name, but your face. You have more levels than these soldiers did. How have these raiders managed to overwhelm you?”

The man bowed his head.

“My King, there is a [Leader] of some kind out there. His Skills are aiding them. Without a commander of our own, we cannot match their tactics! And they outnumber us, us that can fight, that is.”

Flos looked surprised.

“There are no [Strategists] among you? Not a single one?”

There was a shaking of heads. Flos closed his eyes.

“Of course. [Strategists] may find work regardless of age.”

He turned, looked about the steep inclines. There were hills, rising out of the ground, obscuring vision. Flos’ eyes narrowed.

“More of my subjects are trapped in these passes. I must find them. Those of you with arms who can fight on horseback—mount up! You will ride with me! The rest of you—hold this position.”

He looked down at the retired [Axe Guard], the old man.

“Tengrip? Is that your name?”

“My King. You remember.”

Flos smiled. He reached down from his horse and Tengrip caught his hand. Flos turned and pointed at the twins.

“These two are my sworn followers. Trey and Teres. Guard them with your life. They can tell you what passes. Hold this spot, Tengrip. I will return shortly.”

He turned. The attackers’ horses had scattered, but someone in the crowd raised their fingers to their mouth and uttered a piercing whistle. The horses immediately turned and raced towards him.

Men and women followed Flos. Some paused to grasp weapons and even armor from the fallen; the rest mounted up. It was old men, pot-bellied adults, mothers and grandmothers who raced with Flos away from them.

Trey stared. Then he heard Tengrip’s voice.

“You heard the King! Grab weapons! Grab stones if you need to and form up! Children in the back—you lot with classes, front!”

People rushed to do as he said. Trey jolted when Tengrip turned towards him. The old man peered at Trey.

“You there, lad. Trey, was it? Do you have any classes in fighting?”

“N-no. Not really. I can use a sword. Sort of.”

“Best you’d give that horse to someone who can use it, then. Here! Reddy!”

He called out to another old man, and Trey found himself getting off the horse and letting an elderly man who looked like he was all skin and bones mount up. He only had a staff in his hands, but he looked more at ease sitting in the saddle of Trey’s horse than he had standing.

“You, girl. Give your horse up.”

Teres stared at Tengrip, but let herself be persuaded to give up her mount as well. The twins stood standing with hearts racing as the people around them rushed about, arming themselves, helping the wounded—or mourning the dead.

“This your first battle, boy?”

Tengrip’s hand startled Trey as he stared at the dead bodies. The boy turned to him. Tengrip made Trey face him.

“Looks like it. Blue as an unripe Yellat, aren’t you? Well just look at me. Breathe. You said you can use that sword?”

“Yes.”

“Draw it.”

Tengrip watched as Trey unsteadily unsheathed his sword. He made Trey swing a few times for him, and nodded. By the time that was done, Trey had forgotten about the bodies. Or rather, he’d begun to focus on more pressing issues.

“The King is awake! And he’s riding to save us, alone no less! Why ain’t Orthenon with him, or Lady Mars? Or Lady Gazi? I heard they were all at the capital!”

Tengrip was interrogating Teres. She was trying to explain about the *army*, and how Mars had to stay at Reim and Orthenon and Gazi were leading an army against one ten times their size.

“Can’t worry about that! Can’t worry—soon as the King hunts down the rest of the raiders we’ll be at the city! There’s thousands of us headed towards Reim—enough to hold the walls. You’ll see. The King’s back. He even remembered me! Tengrip!”

“That’s not your name, is it?”

Trey felt it was a silly question as he stared at the bloody axe Tengrip still hadn’t bothered to wipe. The [Sergeant] grinned at him.

“‘Swhat the fellows in the army called me. And if the King says it’s my name, well, it’s better than my old one!”

Then he turned to shout at the people milling about.

“Don’t break formation, you sand-cursed *idiots*! Hold your ground!”

They reacted to the voice of command. Tengrip eyed Teres and Trey, and put them well behind the ranks of people he’d spread out in a box formation. Not close to the center, where those without weapons and the ability to fight were, but far back.

Trey felt that was fair, but Teres protested.

“We can fight.”

“Teres—”

Trey wasn’t sure about that, but Tengrip was adamant.

“You two are the King’s servants. If he says you’re to be defended, you’ll stay back. Don’t worry—if we’re attacked, you’ll see fighting.”

And they were. At first it was tense, Trey feeling every second go by as he held his sword awkwardly in a sweaty hand. And then he was bored, talking with Teres, watching Tengrip show some people how to strike. And then he heard screams and saw riders coming over the hill.

There were ten of them. No—nine. One rider was just a horse, galloping with saddle half torn-off. Trey saw some of them had bows. They loosed arrows the instant they were in sight, and he heard a *scream* as someone was hit.

It was terrifying. The armored people were riding straight at them. But the refugees weren’t idle either. Bows raised. Several people had them, and

arrows forced the riders to raise their shields. One struck a horse and made it rear, throwing its rider off—another caught a man in the shoulder, punching through chain links.

The rest were getting closer, though. It seemed as though they'd be right on top of Trey and Teres! He saw a man raising a sword and forgot he was behind several rows of people. Trey began to move along with a mass of people, but a voice stopped him.

"Hold your position!"

Tengrip's voice made his feet obey. Trey halted, and the riders crashed into the rows of people.

It was a terrible sound and sight. Two of the riders were stopped by the first person—one literally thrown back by a man with a huge tower shield, the second impaling both horse and rider on a pike that was thrust into their path despite the rider's attempts to swerve.

But the rest, six riders, charged straight into the ranks of people. Trey saw flashing hooves as horses reared, saw people beating at the people on horses. Someone was riding towards him. He raised a sword and then Tengrip was in the way. The old man hacked at the horse's neck, and there was blood—

In seconds, it was done. The horse fell, to die in moments and the rider was beaten to death, stomped into the dirt. The other attackers were also dead.

But the broken bones and dead people who'd taken the charge were a testament to the cost. Trey wanted to run or throw down his sword, but Tengrip shouted, and soon the square changed. The wounded were taken to the center, and Trey was closer to the front.

Minutes passed. Hours? Trey heard more shouts and saw more riders. He held a sword as his heart and stomach lurched, but he had passed beyond throwing up. But this time the riders weren't alone.

Cheers rang out as Flos rode towards them, at the head of a huge column of people, most on foot, clutching weapons. His arm was drenched in blood and gore, but he wasn't wounded.

"It is a trap."

He rode straight towards Tengrip and said the words so all could hear. Flos silenced the voices and pointed back the way he had come with Trey and Teres.

“The raiders are breaking off. They’re reforming and making for the pass. There’s more behind us as well—keeping their distance.”

“How many?”

Tengrip asked apprehensively, eying the foothills in the distance. Flos shook his head.

“Many. Many more than there should be for [Bandits] or [Raiders]. These aren’t ordinary brigands either, but soldiers. This is a trap, meant for me.”

“In that case, we’ll hold them off while you escape, my King!”

Tengrip raised his axe, but Flos shook his head.

“I am their target. And I will not abandon my people. No, we will fight here and win or die. Now, assemble! [Archers], to the center of the formation! Those of you with the highest levels and mounts, to me! Tengrip, take charge of the rest and form a line. You will be fighting.”

“Aye, my King!”

Trey wanted to speak with Flos. But for once the King had no time for him. He was organizing the frightened people like soldiers. No, turning them into soldiers. The desperate, fleeing people had weapons now, and a leader. They were inexperienced, but there were hundreds of them, thousands. They were ready to beat their enemy to death with rocks or their fists if they had to.

For their King.

But it might not be enough. Trey heard the *thumping* in his bones before he saw the army. It was a *thud*, like a drumbeat. But what drum could make the very earth shake?

He got his answer when he saw the army. They emerged from the hills, surrounding the square of people and the mounted group led by Flos. Trey saw archers taking positions on the hilltops and soldiers waiting in clusters.

But the main force of the army came down the road they had travelled, hundreds of soldiers, and mounted warriors.

And at their head, a man dressed in bright yellow robes, standing next to an armored man with a purple feather on his helm. But it was the robed figure the *thumping* was coming from. Every time he took a fourth step, the earth shook around him.

“[Mage]. High level one, it looks like.”

Tengrip spat the words as the army slowed, blocking the pass. Flos stared at the enemy commander, glancing to the hills. He nodded to Tengrip.

“Have the highest-level archers pick off those on the hilltops. Don’t engage them unless they come down; focus on those ahead.”

“Yes, my King.”

“Flos of Reim! You are surrounded and outmatched! Give yourself up and we will spare your subjects!”

The commander had begun to shout. His voice was faint; he didn’t have Flos’ incredible lungs or a Skill. Flos glanced at him and then at the mage. The man in bright yellow robes was staring at Flos, and there was a grim look in the King’s eyes as he stared back.

They were the true centers of this moment, Trey felt. The [Commander] was barely a speck in Flos’ eye. He kept shouting though.

“—Surrender yourself now, or your people shall be slaughtered! You cannot—”

“Riders! On me!”

Flos turned, ignoring the man, and raised his sword. The old men and women following him shouted and raised their weapons. Flos pointed—not at the [Commander], but at the [Mage].

“Ride with me! You are my blade, my spear! My [Royal Vanguard]! Charge!”

He kicked his warhorse forwards and the people screamed as they followed him. The stunned [Commander] had to withdraw into the lines of

soldiers as the sixty or so riders raced after Flos, into the ranks of the soldiers.

“Charge! For the King!”

Tengrip ran forwards and the group of men and women with warrior classes ran forwards. People around Trey and Teres began firing arrows at the soldiers on the hilltops. The twins stared at Flos as he raced across the dusty ground, aimed straight for the [Mage] in yellow robes. They saw the magic-user grin, and then twist his hands.

The earth split. Stone walls rose in front of Flos, knocking aside the [Mage]’s own soldiers, forming a wall between him and Flos. The King swerved, cutting left into the army. Stone shards exploded from the [Mage]’s grip, cutting through the air. The [King] swung his sword and cut several from the air.

A woman riding behind him fell, a spike sticking out of her stomach. Then the soldiers were clashing with Tengrip’s warriors, and Trey saw the old man’s axe biting. The ground was red with blood already and screams filled the air. The smell of fear and sweat was in Trey’s grip, and the smell of iron too.

The battle had begun.

They were losing the battle. But then, Maresar knew that was the point.

Mounted, loosing arrows into the fog with her group of archers, Maresar turned when she saw the figure appearing out of the fog. She had an arrow ready, but relaxed it when she saw Gazi.

“You’re wounded.”

The half-Gazer staggered towards Maresar, and the woman saw the black smoke rising from Gazi’s armor before she felt the heat. Gazi gasped.

“[Mage]. Got me. Hit me with a [Flare Orb].”

Her armor wasn't brown anymore. It was black with soot in places, but red blood had painted it liberally as well. Gazi's two-handed sword was also crimson and dripping. Maresar's hands moved and she kept loosing arrows as she spoke.

"How long?"

"Two minutes. Orthenon needs more time."

"He needs to retreat. Tell me where."

Gazi was still panting, but Maresar saw two of her eyes turn, roving the clouded battlefield. She pointed.

"There. She's mounted—aim up."

"This high?"

Maresar aimed, calculating for the arc of her arrow, and loosed in an instant. Gazi waited a heartbeat and then shook her head.

"No. To the left two feet and down half a foot. That's their head."

"Fine."

Maresar loosed a second arrow. Gazi nodded.

"Down. Straight through the chest. Next—over here. They've got a barrier spell up."

"So what am I supposed to do? I don't have any enchanted arrows."

"Hit the horse."

Gazi's rasped commands let Maresar target three more mages in the mist. She killed one more, and only distracted two, but it was enough. The fog persisted a few more minutes as the [Mages] were forced to scramble for cover rather than focus on dispelling the enchantment.

That done, Maresar turned back to firing into the mist. She couldn't see anything, even with her Skills, but she didn't have to look. There were so many soldiers all she had to do was loose arrows and she'd hit someone.

"How are we doing?"

"We're being cut up. We can't hold much longer."

Gazi was staring at the place in the fog she'd come from. The place where she'd gone with Orthenon, leading them straight to the center of the army.

It was a tactic that required the fog arrows to occupy the army. It could only work on a coalition army, too. The soldiers didn't recognize each other, and some were too afraid to enter the fighting for fear they'd attack each other. Some did, and began killing their allies. But it was all to get to the enemy command, Maresar knew.

They'd charged the entire army in, save for the archers led by Maresar. A wedge had been driven into the enemy army, a spear aimed straight at the center. But it was a thin, brittle spear. Maresar knew the lines of soldiers were collapsing, struggling to fight an enemy on both sides that vastly outnumbered them.

"I'm going back in."

Gazi gripped her sword, coughing. Maresar kicked her mount and blocked the Gazer's way.

"Not a chance. You're too weak without your main eye."

"Orthenon needs help."

"He can do without you. You just took a spell to the chest. Even with your armor, it nearly got you. If you can't dodge that, you'll just get killed."

Gazi opened her mouth to protest, and then all four eyes swiveled across the battlefield at once.

"The fog's lifting! Orthenon's...a few more seconds. He's nearly killed half—he's moving! Be ready!"

"At last!"

Maresar turned her horse and raced down the line of her archers, shooting.

"Volley the soldiers to the right and left of the formation! Loose!"

Her archers turned. They began to shoot, avoiding the patch of fog where their own soldiers lay. Maresar put an arrow to her own bow and began loosing arrow after arrow, as fast she could.

They only had a few more seconds to do as much damage as possible. And then...it would depend on Orthenon whether the plan had worked as well as not. If he could kill the enemy [General], excellent. But that wasn't the plan. The plan...

Was simpler than that.

He had truly thought he was going to die. But as Uleth stared at the heavy ranks of soldiers between him and the struggling warriors on horseback, he knew he would live.

Orthenon was fighting in the center of the scrum of soldiers, slashing with his spear as if it were a sword. He'd killed a score of Uleth's finest soldiers, but it wasn't enough. Uleth gripped his sword's hilt, but made himself let go. A [General] didn't need to fight and risk his life. He had mobilized the nearby regiments and they were all converging on this position. A few seconds and he'd have Orthenon cornered—

The tall, gaunt man on horseback raised his spear. There was no mistaking his voice, even over the clash of arms.

“Withdraw!”

He shouted and turned his mount. To Uleth's disbelief, the soldiers began withdrawing, falling back, disappearing back into the fog.

But it was lifting too. And as Uleth stared, he saw the battlefield swim back into focus. Only now did he see the huge line of soldiers, like an arrow, penetrating the ranks of his soldiers, pulling back. It was insanity. If they had tried that in the daylight, they would have been overrun from every side. But in the fog, where no one could see who was friend or foe—

“Crush them! Don't let Orthenon escape!”

The order came too late. As the soldiers returned to their formations, Orthenon and his riders raced past. Uleth saw the [Steward] stab a soldier through the helmet as he charged his mount down the pathway he had created, back towards safety.

Uleth turned, almost blinded by fury.

“I want every mounted warrior out there hunting him down! Now!”

He looked for the [Strategist] from Germina, but the man was nowhere to be found. Uleth had to shout before one of the [Tacticians] ran towards him, face pale. Uleth screamed at him.

“Where are my [*Strategists*]?”

“They’re all dead! All—there’s only the lesser [Tacticians] alive!”

“*What?*”

But it was true. Caught so close together, without their shields of soldiers, Orthenon’s men and the [Steward] himself had cut right through the [Strategists] and [Tacticians]. *That* was why he’d attacked, surely.

An army without [Strategists] was slower. Weaker. Uleth could feel his blood boiling in his veins. But they were still outnumbered. He snapped at the frightened [Tactician].

“What are you waiting for? Surround them and kill them all!”

His [Horncaller] raised the horn and blew the call to attack. But it was too late. Uleth stared in disbelief as Orthenon’s mounted cavalry retreated. As did the [Archers]. And the footsoldiers. The entire force of the King of Destruction’s army began to retreat as fast as they could from the battlefield.

This was war. Trey found himself hacking at a man with a shield, screaming as he tried to strike the man, stab him through the faceguard. Then someone cut into the man’s side. Teres shoved her blade deep as the soldier screamed and fell back.

They were alive. For a few more seconds. Trey turned, shaking, from the group of soldiers who’d attacked the square of refugees from the rear. He looked back towards the real battle.

With Flos. The King of Destruction was racing through the heart of the soldiers as if they were grass, cutting left and right, arm moving almost too fast to see. And behind him rode the vanguard, the old men and women. And they were...*slaughtering the soldiers*.

“How?”

Trey whispered it. He saw a woman who could have been anyone’s mother crack someone’s head open like an egg with a mace, and then smash someone in the chest. The people behind Flos were fighting like you saw in movies, like they were untouchable!

“It’s his Skill! It has to be!”

Teres screamed it in Trey’s ear. [Royal Vanguard]. But that couldn’t be it. Not just that. Because across the battlefield, the refugees were giving the enemy army an incredible battle.

The group of people on foot had charged into the ranks of soldiers and begun hacking them apart with the same incredible display. Trey saw Tengrip, slashing about him with an axe.

“He’s old! How can he do that!?”

“Because he’s *old*!”

“*What?*”

Trey stared at his sister. She stared at the battle, her sword wet with blood, a look of—excitement?—on her face.

“They’re old! Retired! But they were all warriors! Think of how many levels they have!”

Trey thought. Then he saw Tengrip struggling with a huge man. He was darting back as the other man, holding a much larger axe, tried to cut Tengrip in half with it. But the [Axe Guard] slid forwards, and then he did something with his axe—

Teres clapped a hand to her mouth and Trey’s stomach lurched as Tengrip cut sideways with one hand. The huge soldier had a shield, but it was like it didn’t exist. The axe struck the shield. The metal deformed, and then the blade of the axe cut into the man’s body, through his armor, into his side, rending skin, tearing his body in half—

The huge soldier fell without a word. Tengrip staggered away. He'd lost his axe. He limped away from the battle, towards the square of refugees. He was bloody, but grinning as he saw Trey and Teres.

"Still alive?"

"Where are you going?"

Teres stared at Tengrip, as if he hadn't just killed at least eight soldiers himself. The old man wrinkled his nose and lifted his right hand.

"I'm tired and I think I sprained my wrist. I'll leave the rest of the fighting to you lot."

His wrist was hanging loosely, as if it wasn't...attached properly. Trey stared at it.

Fragile bones.

Then someone grabbed his arm. Trey stared into a woman's face and saw more soldiers were breaking off towards them.

"Get ready!"

The fighting was reaching their position in the line. Trey saw bodies pressed together, hacking at each other, and then he was in the middle of it again. Tengrip was hacking at someone with his off-hand, and Trey was trying to block something—and then—

"Look out!"

The world went dark. Trey looked up, and saw something huge pass overhead. He felt the earth shake. He looked up.

A huge boulder, bloodied, three times as large as a horse, had just landed. It had crushed dozens of people and—and rolled.

There was blood and...and...Trey stared at what was left of the people after the boulder had hit them. He turned, forgetting about the battle and saw the [Mage].

He was standing alone now, at the center of the clashing soldiers. His hands were raised, and he was pointing. Every time he pointed, a spire of stone would shoot up from the ground, impaling those above. Then the

[Mage] put his fingers together and another spray of rock fragments shot out, shredding a group of people that had tried to charge him.

Two figures dominated the battle. Flos, racing through the soldiers, cutting them down like grain. And the [Mage], casually killing everyone he saw with a gesture.

And they were aiming for each other, the King and the [Mage]. Flos turned his mount, beheading a man and rode straight at the [Mage], ignoring the people in his way. But the [Mage] raised a finger and Flos threw himself from the saddle. Jagged spears of stone shot from the earth, impaling the soldiers around Flos and his horse—his own side.

But he was still aiming for Flos. The King leapt sideways, as more stone darts shot across the ground like hail. He deflected some with his sword, but more struck him on the chest and arm. Trey saw Flos stagger and cried out.

A huge boulder rose from the ground in front of the mage. It hovered and then shot at Flos like some ancient cannonball. The King dodged by a hair's breadth. The boulder shot through the ranks of soldiers, sending bodies flying like bowling pins. But there was a difference between pins and bodies crushed, turned to red paste by the [Mage]'s spell.

He was doing as much damage to his side as Flos'. But he was closing in on the King. And so, for the first time, Trey saw Flos run. The King darted through the ranks of soldiers. He leapt—at least six feet into the air!—and kicked a horseman out of the saddle. Flos kicked the horse and ran as more stone spires burst out of the ground behind him.

“Fall back!”

He roared it and the people broke away, running across the ground towards the refugees. Far less. Far fewer. And the [Mage] still kept casting spells.

The earth broke around the fleeing people. Spears of stone stabbed up—stone arrows struck their backs. The spellcasting only stopped when one of the archers around Trey began shooting at the [Mage]. The first few swerved before hitting him, but the [Mage] immediately raised stone slabs, covering him from attack.

Trey saw Flos riding towards them, gripping his side. He had a potion in his hands, but he thrust it at a man who was trying to hold his insides in. He had jagged bits of stone embedded in his very skin. Flos was holding a hand over his ribs and he was bleeding.

He stopped before his subjects. They called out to him, but Flos stared until he saw the twins. He slowly walked his horse towards Trey. He coughed and Trey heard a wheezing sound as Flos spoke.

“I fear...I may have been outmatched. By a single [Geomancer], no less.”

There was no despair in his eyes, no denial either. Only grim determination, and...acceptance. He would go down fighting.

Trey looked at Flos, and then stared at the other army. They were forming into ranks. Fewer of them...far fewer. But still several hundred. And the [Mage] stood in an open space in the center of that army.

They weren't moving to attack. They had taken up the same formation as the refugees, in fact. A close box around the [Mage]. They were going to let him kill everyone.

The man in yellow robes wasn't casting spells. Not yet. He was drinking from a bottle. A mana potion? He tossed it aside and raised a hand. An arrow flying at him broke on a second shield of stone.

Flos turned his mount. He looked around, and saw only a dozen of the people who'd charged with him. But they rode towards their King, holding their weapons at the ready, not a trace of fear in their eyes.

“I have one Skill I could use. If this were an army. But it is not. These are my people. Not soldiers. If I had an enchanted blade, or armor like Gazi...but I do not. And I have few Skills that can be activated.”

Flos looked at Trey, eyes full of regret. He sighed, and raised his sword. All was silent as Flos shouted.

“The King of Destruction rides! Who will come with me?”

This time everyone shouted. They raised their blades, and Trey found himself raising his sword. The refugees, thousands of them, prepared to charge. Together they could—

The [Mage] clapped his hands. The ground turned to mud ahead of him, a wet, deep bog. Flos' eyes narrowed. He pointed to the hills.

"Around, then. If he cuts us down by the hundreds, we must still charge. Do you understand?"

Trey's heart was beating out of his chest. This was it then. Flos sighed. He looked at the twins and then raised his sword.

"One last time, then."

He opened his mouth to shout the command to charge, and halted. His eyes widened. Trey saw the King's grim expression change. He stared past the army of soldiers, past the [Mage] in yellow robes and breathed one word.

"Mars."

They were running. In full retreat. Gazi was on horseback and she felt her burnt skin screaming every time her horse took a step. But she had to run. They all had to run.

An army of tens of thousands was hot on their heels.

They had done it. The enemy [General] was enraged beyond belief. He didn't have any clever strategies, any schemes. He wasn't using his [Mages] or siege weapons. He was just trying to crush their small force with his own.

His soldiers were charging, but they weren't faster than the soldiers that Orthenon had picked. And he had his own Skills that let them race across the ground. Even a foot soldier could cover miles in full armor with Orthenon leading them. It was the cavalry that was the true danger. Gazi's head turned and she snapped at the man riding ahead of her.

"Another group. Two hundred, coming from the left!"

"The Second Horse, on me! Crush them!"

Orthenon turned his mount and a group of riders broke away. They shot back, meeting the armed [Lancers] in a clash of weapons. Gazi saw Orthenon's sword blur. He'd tossed away his spear to use his Skills.

[Sword Art: The Tide Breaks]. Five warriors racing at Orthenon crumpled from their saddles, cut straight through their armor by devastating slashes. Orthenon cut again and his blade scythed through a lance. It was enchanted.

But it wasn't enough. Not alone. Not against an army. Orthenon used a second Skill even as Gazi watched, striking all around him.

[Sword Art: Scattering Petals on the Wind]. This too killed as his enchanted blade cut in every direction. But he was running out of Skills to use.

"Gazi!"

Someone rode past her. Maresar was still loosing arrows from her bow, picking off riders on their trail. She shouted at the half-Gazer.

"How many more miles?"

"Twelve!"

They raced across the dry ground as an army poured across the flat landscape after them. Gazi felt her horse panting for breath. Would they die before they reached the city? She didn't know. She saw a group of warriors—elites by the look of them—riding camels and bearing down on a group of fleeing soldiers. Gazi gritted her teeth and turned her mount. She rode back, unsheathing her sword.

Twelve miles.

"Mars."

It was one word. A whisper that carried. Flos stared at a hilltop. Trey followed his gaze.

"Mars? But isn't she—"

“Guarding the city. But if she heard of the battle she would have come.”

“She’d need an army! What about the city?”

“No. She wouldn’t need an army. Look.”

Flos pointed and Trey saw her at last. A figure in shining armor on a hilltop, red hair blowing in the wind.

“She came alone.”

It was like a dream. There stood Mars, her silver armor buffed, her hair caught by the setting sun. But this was also reality, and Trey’s blood ran cold.

“She’s alone?”

She couldn’t be. No one could be that stupid. But Mars raised her sword and took the shield from her back, and Trey saw she was indeed alone. And now the enemy had seen her too.

A cry went up as the [Mage] lowered his stone shield, preparing to cast a spell. He had a staff in his hands now, and the orb at the top shone with a bright light. He turned his head with a look of irritation and went still when he saw the figure on the hill.

“My loyal Mars. Yes.”

“What is she *doing*? She’s not even wearing a helmet!”

Teres fought her way over to Flos, pale with fear. Flos laughed.

“She has a helmet.”

But she wasn’t wearing one. Trey watched as Mars raised her sword to point at the [Mage], standing in the center of the ranks of soldiers. She struck her shield with her blade, and then Flos raised his voice.

“One of my Seven is here!”

Many hadn’t seen her. Trey heard shouts and exclamations as heads turned up, and people spotted Mars. Flos shouted over the cheers.

“Who is my [Vanguard]? Who strikes fear into the hearts of my foes?”

He rode down the line of people, and they shouted.

“Mars!”

“Who is my champion?”

“*Mars!*”

They screamed her name. The enemy was turning, forming into ranks to face the [Vanguard], the lone member of the King’s Seven. They were treating her like an army herself. But Trey looked at Mars’ bare head. He saw the [Mage] raising his staff.

And he feared what would happen next.

It started slowly. Mars began racing down the hilltop. She was a distant figure, armor flashing silver as she ran. Her shield was raised, her sword held at her side. She looked like a surging wall of metal.

A group of cavalry rode to meet her. Each warrior had a lance. They thundered at Mars as she hit flat ground, aiming their lances at her heart.

Trey cried out as they met her. The lances struck Mars’ shield. Four lancers struck her with all the weight of a horse behind them. And Mars—

Stopped.

She didn’t move. The lances *broke* and two of the riders were thrown from their saddles by the impact. The other two galloped past Mars, riders knocked back by the force of the blow. Mars raised her sword and stabbed the two fallen warriors almost perfunctorily. Then she ran on.

“Impossible.”

Teres breathed the words. The soldiers were just as stunned. Then the archers began to loose arrows. They rained down on Mars but she didn’t bother to lift her shield. They struck her armor, breaking and bouncing off the shining metal. And they struck her head.

And those arrows broke too. Trey’s jaw fell open as Mars ran on. He saw an arrow *strike her in the eye* and shatter as if it had hit steel.

“Prepare to charge.”

Flos’ voice broke him out of the moment. He was staring at Mars, and someone else.

The [Mage]. The [Geomancer] watched Mars racing towards him, eyes narrowed. She struck the first line of soldiers with a *clash* that Trey heard

even from a distance. Mars' shield swung like a mace, edge striking a man's face and caving it in. Her sword flashed, and two warriors stumbled back, falling. But she didn't *stop*.

Swords cut her. A mace fell towards her face and Mars blocked it. She charged into the ranks of soldiers, and they were forced back. They couldn't stop her. A pike *snapped* as Mars ran onto it. She ran on, soldiers falling back, tossed aside, helpless to block her way.

But the [Mage] just watched Mars come. He gestured with his staff, and a hail of stone shards burst out of the orb, striking Mars. The stone tips broke on her armor.

The man frowned. A boulder rose out of the earth, forming itself from bits of stone, and shot towards Mars. She stopped then, and braced herself. The huge stone struck her shield and Trey *felt* the impact. It was stone that broke. Not Mars.

She ran on. Now the [Mage] had lost his confidence. He sent a wave of spikes shooting upwards, but they could have been grass for all they hindered her. He tried to hit Mars with another boulder, but she blocked again.

"She's going to get him."

"Not quite. He has one stronger spell."

Flos' voice was quiet. He was watching Mars as she cut through a group of soldiers trying to protect the [Geomancer]. And he was right.

The [Mage] raised his staff and struck the earth with it. Suddenly, Mars was wading through mud as the earth turned to sludge beneath her. The [Mage] raised his staff over his head, mouthing words, and now Trey felt uneasy. Something was happening.

A huge stone formed out of the dirt, the earth caving in around it and drifting upwards, compacting into a mass of stone and dust. The same thing that the [Mage] had thrown towards Trey earlier.

It was bigger than a car—the size of a small bus. Trey could see the [Mage] struggling to lift it. But he had an easy target. Mars was stuck, trying to reach the edge of the mud pit. She halted and raised her shield as

the stone rose. The [Mage] threw it with one motion. It shot towards Mars and the impact shook the earth.

And this time Mars didn't block. The boulder crashed into the mud, sending it shooting up around it. When it fell, there was no silver figure. No Mars.

A groan went up from the people around Flos. They cried out, and the soldiers around the [Mage] raised a cheer. He turned, arms held high as they cried out in victory. Trey looked at Flos—

And saw the King was smiling.

She walked out of the air itself as the [Mage] was laughing in delight. Mars appeared, her form fading into existence, rather than out of it. The [Mage] hadn't seen. He heard the cries of alarm too late. Mars ran him through and he stared at her, completely surprised.

"Now."

Flos' voice rose and he shouted as Mars spun away from the [Mage], raising her sword. Flos raised his and bellowed.

"For Mars and glory! To me!"

They ran forwards, shouting. And Trey was right behind Flos until they met the enemy. He saw the King riding towards Mars as she fought, surrounded by soldiers on all sides. He thought he saw Mars laughing. He knew Flos was.

They weren't going to make it. Gazi slashed left and someone cut her on the cheek. She hadn't seen it coming.

"Gazi!"

Maresar shot the person who'd wounded her. Her fingers were a blur as she nocked arrows and loosed in one motion. One arrow. Two arrows. Five...seven...each time she loosed, another soldier on horseback fell.

They were so close. Gazi kicked at her horse, but the animal was wheezing. It was at the end of its tether. She leapt from her steed and stumbled.

Someone caught her. Orthenon spurred his mount, his bloody sword in hand. There was the wild fury of battle in his eyes.

“What are you waiting for!? We’re nearly there! Run, damn you all! *Run!*”

They ran. Reim’s gates were in the distance. They were so close. But they were too slow. The enemy caught them at last.

Afterwards, Trey realized he was standing on the dead [Mage]’s body, a staff in his hands. He was panting. He had a deep, deep cut on one arm—if he looked he could see something like bone. The staff shone in Trey’s grip as he bled on it.

“I think it’s his. But I took it.”

He babbled at Teres when she found him, sword bloody. She stared at his arm and screamed for help.

Flos ran towards them and covered Trey’s arm with his, pinching the flesh together. That hurt and Trey told him so. But then Mars was running over, armor pristine, hair still blowing like an action hero. She didn’t even have a speck of blood on her. Not a bit. Trey found that weird.

“I have a potion. Here.”

She took a small bottle out of...somewhere, and uncorked it. Trey gasped as it was poured over his wound and then he saw the cut on his arm close. He blinked at Mars and then his head cleared a bit.

“Ow.”

“Are you injured anywhere else Trey? Teres?”

“No. I don’t think—no.”

Teres wasn't injured either. Flos stared around the battlefield. The enemy soldiers were either dead or fleeing. Their [Commander] might have been among them—it didn't seem to matter. Their spirits had broken when the [Mage] had been killed, and between Flos and Mars, they had carved up the soldiers.

Now Trey stared at Mars. Mars the Illusionist. The [Vanguard]. The most useless of the King's Seven when it came to anything but war. But war...she was pretty good at war.

There was not a scratch on her. Not a bit. And no blood, although it was practically matted in Flos' beard. It was a mystery that Trey was on the verge of solving. And then Flos solved it for him.

"Mars. You have my deepest gratitude."

"I disobeyed your orders, my King. I wouldn't have come, but I received a message from a certain son of a certain vassal you might know."

"No. Venith's boy?"

"He told me you were in danger. So I rode out against your command. I apologize, my King."

She bowed to him. Flos laughed softly.

"I am a fool. Were it not for you, I would be dead, I think. And if the city still stands, this will be a victory on all fronts."

"There were no other enemies nearby, which I found odd. So I took a horse—I left it somewhere so I wouldn't get it killed."

Mars was still smiling, looking as beautiful and sounding as nonchalant as ever. But she was surprised when Flos dismounted and came towards her.

"Mars. Enough modesty. You saved my life. I would look on your face now, and speak my thanks to my vassal myself. Your true face."

She hesitated. Mars lost her usual swagger, and glanced at Trey and Teres.

"In front of them?"

"If you are uncomfortable, they will turn away. But I want to see you, Mars."

Flos' voice was gentle. Trey took hold of Teres' arm, but Mars shook her head.

"No, I—they can—"

She hesitated, and then raised her right hand. She was wearing silver gauntlets, but she twisted at her ring finger. There was nothing there that Trey could see. And then—

The illusion vanished. Mars vanished. The tall, buxom redhead in silver armor vanished. A shorter figure, spattered in blood, grime, and wearing armor that was just grey stood in her place. She had a helmet on her head with the visor down. She wasn't thin, and her breastplate could have been made for a man or a woman.

And then she took off her helmet and Trey saw a woman's face. It wasn't hideous—it was a bit plain, that was all. Mars had pale skin from lack of sunlight, and a few faint freckles. Her hair was brown. And her nose was a bit snubbed. She was sweating heavily. She looked down at the ground, rather than meet anyone's eye.

And Flos bent and kissed Mars on the forehead. She went still. Her eyes were wide. And Flos kissed her again.

"My [Vanguard]. My beautiful vassal."

That was all. Flos stared into Mars' eyes and she looked up at him with tears in hers. By the time Tengrip came over, his broken hand splintered and the people began cheering, Mars was standing next to Flos with her illusion back in place, laughing loudly and waving to the people who cheered for her.

But for a second Trey had seen the truth. And it changed everything. He'd seen the ring she twisted to change her appearance, and remembered the brooch she'd given Flos. Mars was no good at magic. But she had a lot of magic on her.

Mars the Illusionist. And Flos turned towards her, looking at his vassal with pride that had nothing to do with looks. He held out a hand towards her and she grasped it.

"Come, Mars. You too, Trey, Teres. This was only one battle. It's time to win another."

They caught Orthenon's army four miles from their destination. Venith saw the struggling lines of soldiers, trying to fight and run before the rest of the army caught up. They were on the verge of being overrun.

"Mother's there."

By his side, Calac was staring in horror at the endless sea of soldiers. He had probably never seen so many people in his life, and they were all the enemy. But Venith could close his eyes and remember greater armies. But his eyes were open now.

"It's a trap. Not for Orthenon and the others. That army's in the middle of his trap."

"How? There are so *many*—"

Venith glanced at the city of Reim in the distance, the sixteen towers piercing the sky.

"I know what they're doing. Stay back, Calac. Take the foot and archers to your mother."

"But—"

"No arguments. You won't die today. This—is my duty."

Venith rode forwards. His retainers, his sworn friends and companions from another war, rode with him, shouting. They were a handful, but it was enough. Venith found his heart was beating harder, harder than it had beat for many years.

The soldiers had noticed him now. Venith saw a four-eyed stare, a gaunt man turning his head in disbelief, and a woman on horseback, more beautiful than one of Mars' lies, staring at him. It was the only thing Venith had ever wanted to see. That, and one more face.

He raised his sword and shouted.

"In the name of the King of Destruction! *Charge!*"

His soldiers raced with him, cheering and broke upon the startled enemy. Venith rode into them, deep, cutting, slashing, blocking every strike with his shield. He heard a wild sound and realized it was coming from him.

He was *laughing*.

Flos and the small army of refugees reached the city. The King and Mars raced towards the northeastern gate. They saw the army fighting in the distance, and the soldiers running for the city with the last of their energy.

“Venith!”

The King cried out when he saw the man locked in combat, holding the enemy back. Gazi and Orthenon were riding back towards him, but it was Venith’s wife who turned first.

Maresar nocked one arrow and loosed it. She had a second arrow at the string in an instant. She loosed.

In Trey’s vision, two soldiers rushing towards Venith fell. One staggered and clawed at an arrow in his chest; the other fell soundlessly, an arrow protruding from one cheek. More arrows flew, and the people trying to kill Venith fell from their saddles.

“Retreat, you idiot!”

Mars shouted it from the battlements at Venith, as if he could hear. She turned to Flos.

“He doesn’t know about the plan!”

“Oh, but he does. This is Venith. He knows the nature of my city. He knows what we would do.”

Flos answered calmly, but his hands were gripping the stone so tightly Trey feared it might break. His eyes were on Venith.

His vassal.

It looked as if Venith's thin line of soldiers might buckle and break at any moment. They were falling, but the last of Orthenon's army was breaking away. Trey waited for Venith, searching for him amid the fighting. And then—

“There!”

A man was riding backwards, fending off slashes with a shield, several wounded men around him. He rode at breakneck pace towards the gates, his fresh mount outdistancing his pursuers.

“It's time.”

Flos turned from the battlements, a huge grin on his face. He leapt down the stairs and Mars was by his side. They ran towards the gates, where an exhausted group of soldiers had collapsed just inside the city.

“Orthenon! Gazi! Maresar! To me!”

Flos shouted and the three ran towards him. Each one looked battered. Trey had never seen Orthenon looking so haggard, and even Gazi looked tired. But as they reached their King, their faces changed.

“It's time. Form up the rest of the army.”

“Done!”

From his position, Trey could see more soldiers, fresh soldiers, standing at attention. They were ready for battle. But the army approaching Reim was *enormous*.

“We slew a number of their [Mages]. Most of their [Strategists]—couldn't reach the artillery.”

Orthenon gasped at Flos as he drank from a flask. Flos nodded.

“They chased you here. That is what matters. They are too close to the city.”

“They'll be right behind Venith and climbing the walls in seconds. It needs to be now, my King. Gazi—”

“I'll do it.”

Gazi stumbled towards the stairs. Trey saw her climbing with speed towards him. Flos turned towards the gates and bellowed.

“Lower the gates!”

The portcullis began to drop. Shapes galloped through before it closed. Venith leapt from his saddle and hit the ground hard. He strode towards Flos.

“My King.”

“Venith.”

The man tried to kneel, but Flos seized him before he could. Flos wrapped his arms around Venith and hugged him to his chest. There were tears in Venith’s eyes.

“I do not deserve—”

“Do not speak to me of that! A [King] does not remember such things. You are back, my vassal. And now, let us put an end to this.”

“Yes.”

Venith stepped back lifting his sword and shield. Maresar joined him, and they stood together.

“Yes!”

Mars grinned and raised her sword and shield, shouting, and a thousand voices echoed hers. Orthenon raised his blade.

“For the King of Destruction!”

On the wall, Trey realized he was in danger when the first soldiers began firing at the walls, and more began pounding at the gates. He would have run or ducked, but a hand grabbed him.

“This way!”

Gazi pulled him and Teres towards the watch tower. She sprinted up the steps and the twins raced after her. They couldn’t see the soldiers, but they could hear an incredible din through the echoing tower.

“There are too many! We can’t hold them off!”

“That is not needed. We just had to get them to attack the city rather than stay away and lay siege from a distance.”

“Why?”

Trey shouted. He caught up to Gazi at the top of the tower. The half-Gazer was panting, but her four eyes were steady. She grinned and then pointed.

“Accuracy.”

There was something on the walls of the tower. Some kind of... drawing. Trey squinted, and then he saw, partially obscured by dust and filth, a symbol.

No...was it a rune? It was some kind of diagram, a circle, only each line was in fact made of smaller lines, writing that hurt just to look at. It wasn't proper words. It was shapes. Meaning made into written word.

Magic.

Gazi slowly walked over and pressed her hand to the center of the diagram. Slowly, the runes lit up. They glowed faintly at first, and then began to shine. Yellow, the color of the sun, and then brighter still. They became searing white lines, tinged with gold. Like—

Lightning.

Uleth snarled as he screamed for ladders, battering rams, anything to break open the damned walls of Reim. The city's walls were short, the defenders less than ten thousand in number. He would kill them all now—they had nowhere to run!

“Set up the damn trebuchets!”

He shouted at one of his remaining aides, a low-level [Tactician], before remembering he'd left all of his artillery behind in the chase. Even his foot soldiers were barely catching up, winded and exhausted from the run as they were. If they'd had [Strategists], they could have used Skills to reduce the effort of the chase, move faster. Damn Orthenon!

Lacking siege weapons, Uleth spurred his exhausted mount to one of his [Mages].

“I want you to blow down the gates! *Now!*”

“We’ll try, but it will take—”

“*Do it!*”

The [Mage] turned to the others, still panting from their ride and they began to link hands in preparation for the spell. Then one of them turned pale and pointed up.

“Someone on the castle walls is casting a massive spell!”

“What?”

“There! On the tower!”

Uleth spun. He couldn’t see any signs of magical activity—he could barely make out the top of the tower amid the gathering storm clouds. Where had his cursed clear skies gone? It wouldn’t save the King of Destruction though, nothing would.

“Kill the [Mage], then! Bring down that tower!”

Someone threw a [Fireball]. It burst harmlessly on the wall, as did the arrows of magic which failed to even damage the stones they struck.

“The towers are heavily enchanted! And the mage—it’s a Tier 6 spell! *At least!*”

Uleth felt fear worm its way into his stomach. He stared at the tower.

“Impossible. There are no powerful mages present. Amerys is at Wistram. She *has* to be!”

“No! It’s not one person. It’s—the towers!”

Another mage cried out, and now Uleth could see signs of magic. Each one of the sixteen towers of Reim was glowing now, and light was shining from the tips. No—not light.

Lightning.

Electricity was crackling around the towers’ tips. As Uleth watched in horror, it began to shoot out, flickering, reaching out. Not down towards the ground, but towards the center of the city. Towards the palace.

Gazi stood with one hand on the magical sigil, tracing complex patterns on it. It wasn't just a circle, Trey now realized. It was a *map of the city*, formed by the runic writing.

And now he could see the magic working. Trey glanced out the window as lightning flashed.

"W-what's happening?"

"A spell."

Gazi whispered it, all four eyes focused on the runes. She traced a line towards the center of the city, and Trey saw lightning shoot towards the center. It was gathering there. It was impossible for lightning to do that of course, but it was arcing towards the palace, crackling as it danced across the stone exterior. And now Gazi's hand had stopped.

Outside, the electricity gathered into one spot. High above the city, all sixteen towers shot lightning up, towards a...ball of lightning. Gazi paused, and looked at Trey. There was a wild grin on her face.

"Drevish made this."

"*Drevish?*"

"Yes. He studied Drake architecture. They build their cities to fight back even without defenders."

She gestured at the lightning.

"Amerys and Drevish both worked on this enchantment. They called it [Storm Keep]. A spell to destroy entire armies. It was never used. There was never a need."

No army has ever attacked Reim. Trey stared at Gazi and then realized the plan. It was so simple. Lure the enemy close. Only it wouldn't work if they stayed back and knocked the towers down with trebuchets.

Now Gazi turned. She stared out one of the windows, down at the army surrounding Reim. The dark shapes were moving. Fleeing. Running away from the city now the trap had been sprung.

But they were too slow. Too late. Too tired to run fast, and too disorganized. Gazi smiled.

“This is for you, Drevish.”

Then she touched the map. And lightning rained down from the heavens.

Venith watched the lightning fall. He could close his eyes and remember Amerys laughing and coming up with the idea and convincing Drevish to work on the enchantment.

Lightning for a King of Destruction. Lightning for his crown. From his crown. It was something only they could make, something only Drevish could engineer and Amerys could enchant.

Now the thunder rolled nonstop, and the flashes of light split the earth. Electricity arced from soldier to soldier, seeking their metal weapons. And the light fell and men died.

In silence, the King of Destruction and his vassals watched the storm bring down its wrath. Even Amerys couldn't have done as much. Not alone. But as Drevish would have pointed out, this was *architecture*. It was grand and terrible.

And it was merciless. From her tower, Gazi pinpointed [Mages]. Even the best of them on the field couldn't stand more than three strikes of lightning. Then she struck the enemy [General] as he ran, brought down clusters of elite soldiers, and then hit any group she could find. And when it was over, Flos raised his sword.

“You are my army! My army! *The army of the King of Destruction!*”

Thousands of soldiers roared. Venith felt the exhaustion in his arms disappear in an instant. He lifted his sword and shield and felt as light as a feather. The gates opened and Flos led the charge. Venith rode at the King's back, Maresar by his side. Orthenon and Mars flanked the King and they charged the remnants of the army. They were still outnumbered.

But their King was back. And Venith laughed and laughed. Because he was finally happy.

The King of Destruction had returned.

Destruction. It was fitting name for it. When he had first heard the title, Trey had thought it was a rather silly name. A title for someone pretending to be a King maybe, or a mocking name. Not something literal.

But now he stood in a tower, and all he saw was just that. Destruction. The earth was blackened. Fires had started and had to be put out. But it was the bodies that Trey focused on. The broken bodies. The burnt armor.

And the captives. There were thousands of them. More captives than captors, possibly. But they had thrown down their arms rather than face Flos, face his vassals or his army.

Gazi walked slowly down the stairs with Trey and Teres. They had to help her; Trey was the one to notice how gingerly she walked, and the burn marks on her armor. They supported her down the long, winding stairs, awkwardly taking her weight. But Gazi insisted on walking alone to meet her King as he rode back into the city.

Flos was covered in blood. His eyes were still wild with battle, and his soldiers and vassals shouted with victory. Trey stared at them and then saw Teres with that same smile.

But he didn't smile. He felt like a stranger, even more so now than before. A stranger, staring at something he couldn't quite understand. Something that called to Trey. Something wonderful, horrible, enticing, revolting. Something foreign.

Flos dismounted, patting his warhorse as his vassals and subjects crowded around him. He seemed larger than life, the center of the world. Trey heard people praising him, asking him questions. But it was Orthenon's voice that rose above the others.

"The captives, my King. What shall we do with them?"

“We can guard them for a short while. But not for long. They will solve our issue of funding and food for the winter.”

Flos was speaking to Orthenon, smiling broadly. Trey saw Gazi halt as she approached her King. There was a strange look on her face. Flos turned, calling out for someone with magical skill to send a [Message] spell.

“To Roshal! To the Traders! Tell them to send the nearest caravan they have. One should already be close by if they have been watching the battle. Tell them I want all the food and supplies they can sell to me!”

It was strange. Maresar grinned slightly at Flos’ words. Mars didn’t react. Orthenon just nodded calmly as if he’d expected it. Even Venith nodded, looking steadfast. But Gazi looked away.

“The Traders? Who are they?”

Teres whispered to Trey. He shrugged. But a small pit was emptying itself in his stomach.

And it was Gazi who heard. She looked at them, and there was no laughter, no smile in her gaze.

She answered them with one word. One word that changed the world that Trey thought he’d understood.

“Slavers.”

Above them, the sky changed. *Something* flew through the air, and snow began to fall. Just for a moment. Then it melted on the burning ground.

Winter had begun.

4.06 KM

It was the middle of winter when the first of Flos' vassals began to reach his city.

Standing on the balcony on one of the higher floors of the palace, Trey stared moodily down at the procession of armed warriors entering through the southern gates. His eyes were good—too good in fact; Trey's eyes were better at longer distances—and he could see these were a different sort of people. He stared down darkly, shivering a bit as a cold wind blew at his clothing.

The foremost leader of the procession was wearing some kind of veil. It might have been a she or a he—Trey couldn't tell from this far up. And it might not matter, because he recognized the kind of people that were being cheered by Flos' citizens.

String People.

Trey had met a group of them once before, weeks ago. Now he hated all of them, even if these ones weren't slave traders. He knew they were one of the main races inhabiting Chandrar, along with the Garuda and human populations. Well, String People looked human too. Until you got close and saw the stitches keeping their bodies together.

Yes, they looked human, but they were made like Frankenstein's monsters. Their bodies were cloth, and they could be made of any fabric, from tough wool to silk. That actually mattered to them socially; Trey supposed it was a class thing. But a String Person could be built, or repaired by someone with a needle and thread, so long as you had the right cloth.

Actually, according to Orthenon it was harder than that. But Trey hadn't asked him for details. He wasn't speaking to Orthenon right now.

Or anyone, really.

These String People, or Stitch-Men and Stich-Women—possibly Stitch-Boys and Stitch-Girls although they didn't look that young—were on foot. They had long, wicked spears and other polearms and they all had veils on their faces.

They were probably some elite band that had served Flos years ago. It didn't surprise Trey that String People would call Flos their King either; no doubt he would have loved having them in his army. The String People were supposed to be fearless warriors, hardy survivalists, and all the things you said about anyone you wanted to talk up. They didn't fear being cut to death; they could just sew themselves up, after all. In fact, the only thing String People truly feared with a passion was fire.

It was odd that a flammable people would live on the hottest of all continents. Chandrar's days were filled with blistering heat, and the nights were cold enough to freeze to death on. But when you thought about it another way, Chandrar had less vegetation. Fewer things to burn.

Behind the group of Stitch-warriors, Trey spotted another band of people entering. These weren't String People, but they were being cheered just as loudly. They looked like Humans, robed and holding...Trey had to squint in disbelief. Was that an *umbrellas* they were holding?

It made no sense. Winter in Chandrar didn't mean that much snow, and though it could still get very cold, you didn't need an umbrella except if you were trying to keep out of the snow. But Trey was used to strange things in this world.

These people looked like [Mages]. So two groups of his vassals were entering the city at the same time? Trey knew that meant more feasting, and Flos welcoming his vassals into his palace with open arms. He'd certainly thrown a big enough party for Venith and Maresar and they had only been two of his former vassals.

Trey scowled and gripped the railing tightly. He wasn't happy. And he didn't want to be in the banquet hall, sitting at the tables—the ones far from the high table—and have to listen to Flos laugh. He didn't want to see the King of Destruction's face right now. Or anyone's. Right now, Trey hated this entire kingdom.

They were all *slave traders*.

Trey couldn't believe it when he'd found out. Flos had slaves. To be more accurate, he *sold* people as slaves. He'd struck a deal with the Traders of Roshal to sell all the prisoners he'd taken captive in the battle for Reim. Some had been ransomed off, but the rest...

Slaves. Trey couldn't believe it. He couldn't believe Orthenon, or Venith, who had seemed so honorable, would allow people to be slaves! But no one had understood his outrage. And worse...

Trey closed his eyes. It had been over a month since that day when he'd realized the entire continent of Chandrar actively owned or allowed slaves. If some kingdoms like Flos' were too poor to have many slaves, most nations had a good deal of slaves. People, held in captivity. And it had been a month since he and his sister had stopped talking, after they'd fought bitterly about that very issue.

That hurt worst of all. That was why Trey was alone, had been alone, for so long. Because he had fought with his sister. Because Teres wasn't willing to condemn Flos for dealing with slave traders. *Because she was just as bad as the rest of them.*

It had been a terrible fight. It hurt Trey now. He'd had fights with his sister before. That was normal. But fights were supposed to end after a while. There might be tears, or hitting, but in the end, after days, or maybe a week at most, you'd make up. Trey and Teres were twins. Being apart was too difficult.

But this fight was different. It had been bitter and harsh, and the scars weren't healing. Trey could remember every word he'd said when he was alone.

"You think it's *alright*?"

Trey screamed at Teres and threw a chair. Not at her, but a wall. His voice was hoarse; he'd been screaming for a long time. So had she, but she screamed right back.

"You're not seeing the bigger picture!"

"Fuck your bigger picture!"

Trey looked for something else to hurl, but he'd already broken everything else in the room. He turned to Teres, face red.

“He’s keeping *slaves*, Teres! *Slaves!* ”

“He’s not keeping them! Idiot! He’s just selling them!”

“Oh, *just* selling them, is it?”

“You heard him! He’s doing it for his people! Without the money from those merchants—”

“They’re not *merchants*. They’re slave traders!”

“Shut up!”

Teres was red with anger. She’d tried to ‘explain’ Flos’ reasoning to Trey several times before and he wasn’t willing to listen. She took a shuddering breath.

“Flos has to protect his people—”

“By selling other people, is that it?”

“He’s got to keep people fed! You heard Orthenon—we need the coin or we won’t last the winter!”

“So that makes slave trading alright then, is that it? Oh wow, I guess if I’m hungry I should see if I can sell some folks off for a bit of cash!”

“It’s the way things are done here! You don’t have to like it—I don’t like it! But we have to change Flos’ mind, not tell him no—”

“Bugger that! You think we should just let it go? You’re mad!”

“I’ve talked with Flos and he’s listening to me. You’re just making him put his back up every time you start shouting—”

“No!”

Trey was shaking with anger. He felt betrayed. He pointed a shaking finger at Teres.

“I heard you. You think it’s okay? You think it’s okay to keep doing it? To tell Flos he can sell off thousands of people just like that? You’re as bad as the rest of them!”

“I’m *not*—”

Teres looked like she was on the verge of tears or lashing out. Or both. But Trey wouldn’t listen. His voice rose, cracking with emotion.

“You’re as bad—no, you’re worse because you *know* it’s wrong. But you’re bloody sick in the head. You’re so obsessed with Orthenon that you’ll watch his lot sell slaves without blinking twice. You’re not my sister. You’re a monster, you sick, twisted, addled *cunt*—”

That was when she drew her sword and Trey ran for it.

Later, Trey had stormed into the throne room and shouted at Flos. He remembered *that*, too, in anger though, and not regret. He’d marched up to Flos and yelled at him. At the King of Destruction. Somehow, he’d said his bit without Orthenon kicking him out or cutting him to bits, and Flos had quietly shaken his head.

“Slaves are part of Chandrar’s blood and body, Trey. I will not change that. Nor do I disagree with owning slaves. I have explained that to Teres and she understands. I hope you will too.”

Cold fury. Trey remembered shouting at Flos and Orthenon snapping at him to mind his tongue.

“You think it’s okay to sell and buy people against their will?”

“Better than letting them rot in a cell. That is what your world does, is that not true?”

“Yes—but—”

Trey faltered. Flos’ gaze was piercing him like a needle. The King spoke softly.

“For years. For twenty years in cases of murder. Longer for some. Forty years? That is a lifetime. And these people must obey their captors, live by their rules, labor as part of their imprisonment. And you tell me that is not slavery?”

“It’s—it’s not the same.”

“Isn’t it? It sounds like hypocrisy, to me. Your world claims to own no slaves, but you enslave your criminals. Well, in Chandrar we do the same.

Trey, you may have a different name for slaves in your world, and perhaps you do different things with them. But they are still slaves.”

Flos rose, staring down at Trey with cold eyes. Merciless eyes. The same eyes of a King who would slaughter an army that came against him. Why hadn’t Trey seen it until now? He hadn’t wanted to believe it.

“Slavery allows criminals, enemies of my Kingdom, to be *used*, Trey. They are a commodity. Locking someone away for twenty years is crueler to my mind, and far more pointless. A slave cannot be mistreated under a just ruler, and they may be freed if—”

“They’re still *slaves*! Who cares if they’re pampered? They don’t have free will! How could you sell all those people? I thought you were a better King than that!”

That had struck home. Flos’ eyes narrowed.

“Some will be ransomed. The Traders of Roshal are an independent third party. They may ransom those with wealth, and manage those who are not able to buy their freedom. My kingdom needs food and coin for the winter, Trey.”

“I don’t care. You think it’s okay? I think it’s completely wrong. No—I *know* it is.”

Flos exhaled hard. He threw out his hands, more exasperated than Trey had ever seen him.

“What would you have me do? My dungeons cannot hold more than a fraction of their number, and feeding them would beggar my kingdom further. Would you have me execute them all? *I* do not have the stomach for it, and I am the King of Destruction.”

“I’m not telling you to kill them all! You could ransom some of them, and the rest...let them all go if you have to. But don’t treat them like—like —”

In the end Trey had run out of words. He couldn’t explain why slavery was wrong to Flos. He told the King of Destruction the sky was blue, and Flos said it was green. The King had silenced Trey after a while with a wave of one hand.

“You may not like it Trey, but I expect you to live with my decision. It is necessary. Your sister has made her peace with it. So must you. I am your King. And this is my kingdom. So long as you are my subject, you will live by my rules.”

And that was it. Trey stood before Flos, and realized the truth. The terrible truth. He looked up into the face of a man he’d admired, grown to respect, and understand. And he’d shaken his head.

“You’re not my king. I still have a Queen.”

Trey turned and stormed out of the throne room. He hadn’t spoken to Flos on that day, or any day since.

Trey hugged himself as he stood on the balcony, watching the happy people in the streets below. Even now he remembered. And though it was hard, and lonely, being at odds with Flos and his sister, he still knew he was right.

But it was so *hard*. Each day, Trey rose and woke up in a small room, apart from Teres. He ate alone, wandered the city alone, and slept alone. No one wanted to talk to him. He didn’t train with Mars, and she had given up on trying to make him do it. Orthenon refused to speak with him so long as Trey didn’t apologize to the King—

He was trying to make Trey give in. Trey could tell. It was like a pulling, a wanting in his chest that made him feel like rushing back to Flos and begging for forgiveness. It was what Trey imagined an addiction felt like; something that couldn’t be fought and tugged at your insides forever. He wondered if this was what Venith had felt like.

But Trey refused to give in. So he stood on the balcony, watching the procession meet groups of cheering people until someone spoke behind him.

“Trey.”

The young man jumped. He turned and saw Gazi standing behind him. The half-Gazer smiled a tiny bit. She nodded at him.

“I have been looking for you. My King wishes you to join him in his throne room to welcome his vassals.”

Trey stared at Gazi. He hadn’t seen her of late; she’d been riding about, keeping track of the neighboring countries in case one decided to attack again. So far everything had been quiet. Everyone was afraid of Flos. But of course he would send her to hunt Trey down. He hesitated, and then shook his head.

“The King can go bugger himself.”

Trey flinched as he said it. He waited to be hit, but Gazi said nothing. Instead, he heard her sigh.

She sat next to him on the balcony. Literally *on* the edge of the balcony, balancing over the three story drop as if her back were against a brick wall.

“I have been away from the city. But your sister and Mars told me of your quarrel with the King.”

She was looking at him with all four eyes. That was uncanny. Trey turned his head, feeling her gaze staring at him. Staring through him.

“It’s not right. Owning slaves. It’s not right, but everyone here does it. They’re all wrong.”

“My King would say the same of locking people up for years. Isn’t that what you do in your world?”

Trey felt something hot and angry bubbling in his chest. Teres had told Flos’ argument to Gazi? He was furious because he didn’t have a good answer to that. He wasn’t a genius! He hadn’t *studied* the difference between prison and slavery. And it wasn’t about that!

“That’s because they’re prisoners. They’re meant to be punished. Okay, maybe it’s bad too, but slavery is different. It means you don’t have free will. That—that some people are worth more than others. It’s wrong. It’s *inhumane*.”

“An odd word. Especially to someone who isn’t Human.”

Trey flushed.

“I didn’t mean—”

“I understand.”

Gazi held up a hand, still smiling. It was that fake smile she was wearing, the one that hid her real emotions. She paused, staring down at Trey as the wind blew across her armor and the young man shivered again.

“You know, some nations agree with your thinking. In Izril there are far fewer slaves. The Drakes do not tolerate in some cities, and few Gnoll tribes at all. The Humans in the north rarely owned slaves, but [Ladies] such as Magnolia Reinhart put an end to it during her generation. Yet in Terandria, Baleros, and Rhir slaves are legal.”

Trey shook his head. He felt empty inside. Empty and alone.

“So? It doesn’t matter if everyone thinks that way.”

Gazi nodded, as if he’d made a good point. She went on, one eye turning to follow the parade below.

“Not all slaves are treated the same way, of course. In many nations slaves have no rights. But in Chandrar, and in my lord Flos’ kingdom, slaves cannot be mistreated. In fact, my King generally frees any slaves he takes an interest in. And in Rhir and Baleros, a slave can be freed if they fight in battle and prove themselves.”

More arguments. Trey closed his eyes. He searched for the fiery conviction in his heart and just felt tired. But it had to be said.

“Just because you’re a slave for a while—it’s still wrong. If you own someone, you’re not equal to them. Just because there’s a law, it doesn’t mean it’ll ever be right for someone who’s a slave. If you’re owned, someone could do...*anything* to you. And you can’t stop it.”

Gazi paused. She lost her smile, and looked impassively at Trey.

“I understand your thinking. So does my lord, even if he does not agree. He is very upset that you will not speak with him. He wishes you to rejoin his side.”

“No.”

“And that is your decision?”

Trey opened his eyes and looked at Gazi defiantly, although he was afraid of her too.

“Yes. And you can tell that to Flos. Even if you—you drag me to him, I won’t obey him! I won’t pretend everything’s alright!”

“He did tell me to force you to come to him, although he asked me to persuade you first.”

Trey turned to run, but Gazi’s hand shot out. He yelped as she caught his arm. It was impossible to pull away from her; slim though she was and still sitting, she had a grip like iron. Gazi laughed softly as Trey gave up, and then to his surprise, let go. He stumbled back from her.

“What are—”

“He asked. But I am free to disobey. And I will on this matter, and this alone.”

Gazi remained seated on the balcony’s railing. Trey eyed her. He warily took a few steps back towards the doors, ready to flee, but she didn’t move. And probably everyone was on the lookout for him. He hesitated, and then slowly walked back over to Gazi. He stared at her, and all four of her eyes met his.

“Do you believe in slavery?”

She didn’t smile. For once, Gazi didn’t smile. She turned her head, and the corners of her mouth turned down ever so slightly.

“I believe in it. But I do not *like* it. I am alone in that opinion. I think my King has forgotten that. And so did I, until I heard what you shouted.”

Something. Trey felt something tug at his memory. Back then when Gazi had told them who the Traders of Roshal were, he’d seen her face. She hadn’t smiled then.

“You don’t like slaves either? Why?”

Gazi smiled. But it was a rueful smile. It was awkward, unpracticed, as if she seldom made that kind of face. And she looked down at the ground as she replied.

“I was a slave, once. Until my King freed me.”

For some reason, part of Trey had expected that reply. It was still a surprise, but after a moment it made Gazi's character, her loyalty, everything, more understandable to Trey.

"Oh."

He thought for a second.

"I'm sorry."

She looked surprised. All four eyes slowly looked Trey up and down, focusing on him. Gazi nodded.

"Yes. You are, aren't you? That is surprising too. Few people are sorry to hear I was a slave."

Trey hesitated. He wanted to ask.

"Were you—I mean, why did—"

"I was born a slave. But my King found me when I was a child. He bought me and freed me within a year. Ever since then I have served him."

"Oh."

It was stupid to say the same thing again, but Trey was no linguist. He carefully rested his arms on the balcony. He stared at Gazi as the wind blew her hair slightly. The Gazer looked a bit melancholy, distant, and wistful. She was remembering. She wasn't wearing a mask. And she was speaking the truth to him. Her truth.

"I was a slave. I know what you speak of, Trey. I have seen good masters and bad ones. I hate slavery. But my King has never been a slave. He cannot imagine it, and sees it as a fact of life. Slaves in his kingdom are treated well and they can be freed when he orders it. Why should he hate slavery? Venith, Maresar...even Mars and Orthenon have grown up knowing a slave can be well-treated and respected. But they have never been a slave."

"Haven't you told them what it's like? Have you ever tried—"

Gazi nodded. She closed all four eyes.

"Many times. But it is not an argument I ever won. Slavery is part of the wealth of Chandrar, part of crime and punishment. You may be executed if

you wish, or you may become a slave. So it is framed as a choice, and there is a chance for freedom. But it is only that. A chance. An illusion. If I could end slavery, I would. Regardless of the cost. But my King will not hear of it.”

She clenched one gauntleted fist. Trey nodded. He had another question, so he asked it.

“Why can’t Flos just—I don’t know, fight against the slave traders? What if I—we—suggested that to him? He could free all the slaves, and take their money, and I bet the people would join his army.”

Gazi looked surprised, and then she *laughed*. She laughed, and it was a bright, cheerful sound that no one had heard before. Trey’s eyes widened. But then Gazi shook her head.

“The Traders of Roshal are a nation, a power unto themselves. They are similar to Wistram. You know of them? Well, Roshal is just as dangerous in its own way. They have their own army, and more money and wealth than most nations could dream of. They have countless magical artifacts hoarded away, and they would defend their possessions to the death. The Traders of Roshal are dangerous, Trey. Remember that for the future.”

Her eyes fixed on Trey and he nodded, feeling his heart skip a beat. Now Gazi wasn’t smiling, and the air around her was intense. Her eyes swiveled around, checking the balcony, the ground below, the very air. Then she spoke quietly.

“I was only a child, but I saw much with my eyes while I was a slave. The Traders have ways of compelling obedience, of defending themselves. Even Named Adventurers must tread carefully because those who break Roshal’s rules will die, no matter where they are. There are assassins and groups of trained killers that have slain monarchs who go against Roshal. And the Traders have countless thousands of years of knowledge. They know secrets of classes and leveling that my lord Flos does not.”

She fell silent for a moment, and then looked at Trey. And he knew she had not told what she spoke of next to anyone. Not even Flos.

“There are...classes which may be gained by doing the most terrible of deeds, Trey. They cannot be earned any other way. They are not real classes either. They are born of despair and filth.”

“Why are you telling me?”

She grinned at him, a true grin, like the one Mars always wore. Was there a hint of mischief in Gazi’s eyes?

“Because you and I think alike. Of my King’s trusted vassals, you and I understand one truth. And perhaps because I trust you.”

“But I’m just a kid from another world.”

“A child? Perhaps. But you are one Flos trusts.”

“No.”

Trey shook his head, feeling weary and upset again. *Everyone* thought that. But they were wrong! He spread his arms, helplessly.

“I know that’s what Flos says, but look, Gazi, it’s not true. I mean, he thinks I’m special, or I can be. But I’m not. Teres might be special. She can use a sword, but I can’t. I’m just an ordinary fellow. I don’t have any talents.”

Gazi studied Trey.

“Everyone has their own specialty. My King finds it in people. Surely there is something in you that can be used, or shaped. He told me you are a scholar.”

Trey laughed despairingly, laughed in Gazi’s face.

“He *said* that. But it’s not true! I mean, I like to study. I like to play video games. I *like*. But that’s not the same as being good at something, is it? In your—this world, people know what they can do, what they’re good at. But where I come from, some people are just...normal. This world isn’t like mine!”

The half-Gazer pondered while Trey pulled at his hair. She nodded.

“Perhaps that is like this world, after all. Some waste their lives in the wrong class. Others mistake a small talent for a calling. Once I thought all I would do was obey and serve without choice. You are not so different from me, I think.”

“*You?*”

Gazi smiled bitterly.

“Perhaps no one has spoken of it to you? Ah, but Orthenon would not. Mars does not care and my King...listen to me, Trey. In truth, I am the weakest of the Seven, among the living and the dead. I was always the lowest in level. The least able.”

“No. You? Really?”

Gazi shrugged and indicated the sword on her back and her armor.

“I am a [Scout]. Not a specialized class. See my arms and armor? My King had them forged for me, to make up for my weaknesses. But they are still there. I earned my reputation as a dangerous foe, but it is only partly deserved. I worked to make my legend worthy of my King.”

“How?”

Trey edged closer. He was very close to Gazi, and could actually smell her in the cold. She gave off a metallic scent, from her armor no doubt, but there was a spiciness in the air. No—cinnamon. She smelled a bit like that. Spicy cinnamon.

Gazi laughed again, a sound like bells, or the very spirit of them.

“How did I make my name known? It is simple. Fear. All know the name of Mars, and only a fool would not know of Orthenon. But my name is whispered among those who spy and wander alone. Gazi the Omniscient. Of the Seven, my title was given not out of mockery, but hatred.”

Gazi grinned at him, showing off her classic smile. The scary one. But now Trey knew it was just an act. And that she did it on purpose. She looked at Trey, smiling.

“I did it for him, Trey. My King.”

“But he believes in slavery.”

She nodded.

“That is his one great flaw. But he is still my lord. I owe everything to him. So I follow him despite that. Can you understand? He broke my chains. He freed me—not just from being a slave in body, but in my mind.”

“In your mind? Like—how?”

“He told you once that there are secrets of rulers. Secrets only they know of this world and of leveling.”

How did she know that? Trey nodded. Gazi’s eyes searched their surroundings again. Then she leaned forwards and whispered to him.

“The great secret my King knows...one of them is the knowledge that a single class is best. But that is only half of it. The other half is that it is possible to remove a needless class. It is not easy, but it can be done. And only a [King] or other [Ruler] may do it.”

“Really?”

Gazi nodded.

“He took away my chains. I am no longer a [Slave]. A [King] can remove needless classes to those who pledge themselves to him. Orthenon was a [Traitor]. Takhatres a [Cursed Outcast]. My King freed us all of our pasts and gave us a future.”

Silence. Trey understood a bit more. He looked at Gazi. Once, she had been a slave. She had no future, until he’d freed her. He understood that. And yet.

“I can’t forgive him for selling people.”

Gazi nodded.

“I am not asking you to. But you cannot hide forever.”

Something in Trey agreed, but a part of him pulled back. He stared at Gazi, growing a bit angry.

“Is that why you’re talking to me? You’re still trying to persuade me to go to him and say sorry, right?”

A hand smacked Trey lightly on the head. Lightly, but it was still metal. He staggered. Gazi smiled at him. Genuinely.

“I am not forcing you to go anywhere. In fact, I think it will be good if you do not go to my King now. Perhaps later you will sit with me at dinner, but only then. You do not have to change for my King, and perhaps if you do not, he will. No one has ever been able to change my King—Flos—but himself. But perhaps you can.”

And that was why she was here. Trey felt a huge burden on his shoulders, realizing what Gazi was suggesting. But he felt lighter, too. Because he wasn't alone.

For a while the half-Gazer and the young man stood on the balcony, staring down at the last of the procession as it entered the city. It had been a long parade; Trey guessed there were at least several hundred Stitch-warriors and a good two dozen or more of those [Mages].

Gazi eyed Trey. She opened her mouth speculatively, closed it, then asked her question two minutes later.

"You have a [Mage]'s staff in your room. Do you know how to use it?"

"How do you—no, I don't. No one's taught us magic. Orthenon said he'd start, but I haven't spoken to him for a long time."

Trey felt bad about that. He wondered if he would sit with Gazi tonight. If only to speak with Teres. He didn't have to say he was wrong. And he *wanted* to speak with her again. Gazi studied Trey and nodded.

"Perhaps I could teach you some spells?"

He blinked. Trey turned to Gazi.

"You know how to use magic?"

She grinned and one eye winked at Trey. It was a very Human gesture and it made him smile.

"Of course. My people—Gazers—are highly magical beings. They're what you could call a race naturally inclined towards magic, like half-Elves and to an extent, Lizardfolk. But they send very few representatives to Wistram. Their magic is more...chaotic than typical [Mages]."

"So you could teach—"

"Perhaps. We shall see."

They waited a bit longer, as the streets cleared below, and the sun set quickly in a winter sky. It was a pretty world, for all that it was harsh. Trey exhaled and watched his breath spiral up into the sky. Then he asked the question he'd feared the answer to.

"Gazi? What is Flos going to do now?"

She was silent for a very long time, as shadows lengthened on the balcony.

“He will go to war, of course. It is time. The army is ready. With the Serpent Hunters and Parasol Stroll—”

“*Who?*”

Gazi smiled.

“The [Mages] and the [Warriors] you just saw entering the city. I recognized their companies. They are mercenaries now, but they served my King before.”

“I get that, but why Parasol Stroll? That’s their name? Why?”

The half-Gazer shrugged.

“Mages and names seldom make sense. However, in this case each mage in the band has a parasol—a thing to keep the sun away.”

“I know what that is. But *why* do they have one?”

“Fashion. And each one is enchanted in some way. They were powerful mages; each one above Level 20 at the very least. With their companies, my King will no doubt begin waging war.”

Trey’s heart skipped a beat. He paused.

“On who?”

“Those who made war against him.”

Six nations, then. Trey gulped. He remembered the smell of battle, the visions of death. He never wanted to see that again. But he felt he would. Over and over.

“Who’ll be first?”

“His fury is directed foremost towards the kingdom of Hellios and the people of Germina—especially at their leader, the Quarass. When we ride to war, and it will be in days, it will be against her, I think.”

Trey shuddered. His voice was very small and quiet. He felt something squeezing the words out of his chest. He wanted to cry, but it wouldn’t help.

“I don’t want to be here, Gazi.”

She looked at him with a bit of sympathy.

“I know. But you are here. And so you must follow my King. But remember this. You are not alone.”

And she held out a hand, and Trey took it. And the next day Flos did declare war, and Trey found himself marching with the King of Destruction. To the first war on Chandrar. And the news woke up a continent, and the world.

That was six weeks ago.

Now.

The coach that drove quickly towards the estate of the Melissar house was noted from a distance, and the gates were already open and servants were rushing out by the time it pulled up in front of the large manor where other coaches, carriages, and other modes of transportation were parked.

Perhaps a lesser [Lord] or [Lady] or some of the more well-respected and higher-level [Knights] and [Guildmasters] and so on would have had to identify themselves to the guards at the gates. But not so for the occupants of this carriage. The owner was identifiable at a glance, mainly because of the striking appearance of the magical carriage, not to mention the carriage itself.

It was pink. The horseless carriage, or rather, the carriage pulled by ghostly horses that used mana to travel at extreme speed, was painted painfully, eye-searingly, *frightfully* pink. It was said that [Bandits] and other criminals couldn't bear to attack the carriage because of the color.

Which was a shame, because Magnolia Reinhart had standing orders with all of her carriage drivers to run over any [Bandits] they encountered on the road. Several hundred pounds of enchanted wood and metal approaching at speed tended to reduce crime in a drastic and often spectacular fashion.

Still, it was probably a good thing the carriage wasn't covered in blood and bits as the door opened and a tall, stern [Maid] stepped out. After all, this was a social event, and Lady Magnolia knew impressions were important.

Not that she particularly cared. The [Servants] rushing to open the doors themselves backed off as Ressa held the door open for Magnolia. They knew the pecking order, and in that sense Ressa wasn't a bird but a [Hunter] with a bow and arrow.

Magnolia Reinhart stepped out of her carriage, wearing a pink and green dress. Pink and green being colors to describe a dress that looked more like a work of art than actual clothing.

It was a long and flowing ball gown in truth, although it avoided the poofy, ruffled look that Magnolia so detested. One could fit down a narrow corridor without getting stuck, and the dress included actual sleeves and a neckline that didn't swoop or dive, or even hover. Magnolia had no desire to flaunt anything, except for the dress itself.

It was pink and green. It started green from the bottom, the dark green of forest mulch, or cavern moss, and spread upwards, lightening in color and texture, so that when the pink started, and it was a bright pink, a pink that practically shone in itself, you had the impression of a flower. A flower worn by a woman considered by many to be the most powerful Human female on the continent. And she was certainly a contender for a high rank in any world listing as well.

Magnolia Reinhart.

"Ressa, please tell these servants to go away and hurry up and open these doors, would you? I'm in a hurry and if I see a bowed buttocks, I shall kick it. Or order you to."

"Yes, milady."

The servants parted as Magnolia and Ressa strode up the stairs towards the manor quickly, ignoring their greetings and the head servant hurrying after them. Both [Maid] and Mistress walked as if nothing would stop them, and nothing did. Doors opened for them, and they strode into the estate of the Melissar family.

Magnolia was in no mood for formalities. She never was. She strode down the hallway, not needing a guide to head towards her destination. A [Lady] shouldn't stride of course, but Magnolia was a high-level [Lady] and a good one at that, so she managed to stride with grace. One could call it gliding, or some other suitable appellation that might make it more acceptable, but Magnolia knew when she was striding.

She was in a hurry. She let Ressa field the harried [Head Butler] and crooked her fingers at the pair of servants standing at attention at the double doors at the end of the hallway. They opened the doors instantly, and she walked into a huge ballroom filled with the aristocracy of Izril.

“Lady Magnolia Reinhart!”

The [Herald] announced Magnolia without including any of her many titles, nicknames, or ranks. That was at her insistent request as well. The biggest fish didn't need to announce itself. And when her voice was called, the room went silent.

This was the room. It was a marble floored room filled with low-hung chandeliers, magnificent inlays on the walls and pillars supporting the room, and in Magnolia's opinion, decorated with some rather fine silk curtains that complemented the expensive glass windows that looked out onto the rest of the world.

It was a large ballroom—one of the largest around, and no doubt why the Melissar family had been chosen to host this gathering of the nobility. It was a sign of their influence and wealth.

For anyone who could claim to have hosted over a third of the [Lords] and [Ladies] of the north was powerful indeed. And that was who was present.

A sea of heads turned towards Magnolia as she calmly descended the steps into the ballroom. Ressa appeared by her side. The [Head Maid] had not changed her austere black and white dress, but she still attracted her share of glances as well.

No one knelt as Magnolia entered the room. She wasn't royalty, after all. But heads bobbed and some people curtsied. [Lords] dressed in fashionable suits of armor, or wearing cloth suits that were enchanted to be just as protective, bowed to Magnolia as she passed by. [Ladies] dressed in

every fashion from the voluminous and wide gowns Magnolia hated so much to sleek dresses that left little to the imagination—not that Magnolia bothered imagining—made their own greetings.

At another dance or gathering, perhaps the style of the season would be in and everyone would dress alike. But this was a different sort of meeting, and personal uniqueness and flair trumped all. Magnolia's rapid pace slowed to a gentle crawl as she scanned the room.

At first, the room would appear to be a jumble of bodies to the casual outsider, or someone not used to such gatherings. But Magnolia saw the currents in the room. In this room, there were tables set up with tasteful and exotic appetizers, an open central area to dance in, and many places where groups of people stood and mingled.

But it was the groups that mattered. There was an unwritten code here, and a hierarchy. In every circle, there was the most influential, the most powerful, the most high-level or simply the most politically powerful individual who commanded the attention of others, at least for the moment. Politics in Izril was a game of connections and intrigue, of strategy and alliances.

Magnolia had no time for any of it.

"Ressa, find me one of the speaking gems if they haven't started debating already. I'll say my greetings to our hostess, but I don't have time for other nonsense."

"At once."

Ressa turned. There was already a servant hurrying towards Magnolia and Ressa with a pair of sparkling amethysts cut into circles and lined with silver. Ressa plucked the two coin gemstones off of the pillow and handed one to Magnolia. The [Lady] sighed as she gently placed it on the front of her dress where it began to glow with a soft inner light. All of the people around her had a similar gemstone on some part of their garments.

"No one's talking. Well, good. Now, where is Lady Patricia Melissar?"

She looked around. So did Ressa.

"She's not dancing."

“No, and I would expect her to be finding the most handsome man right now. Odd. I wonder if she’s indisposed?”

Magnolia kept looking, and she frowned as her eyes alighted on a man standing alone, drinking from a cup. She sighed as she nudged Ressa with an elbow.

“Ah, there’s Lord Tyrion. How unexpected to see him here...or perhaps not. He’s not dancing either, I see.”

Ressa’s expression didn’t noticeably change, but her mouth tightened in a way only her long-time friend, Magnolia, would notice. Magnolia felt the same way.

“I believe there are few women of sufficient status present he would consent to dancing with. If milady wished, I have no doubt you could invite him to a dance.”

Magnolia shuddered.

“You do have the most dreadful ideas, Ressa.”

The maid smiled ever so slightly.

“I could obtain some suitably heavy boots if you wish.”

Magnolia laughed lightly, and the people hovering close to her but not so close as to be assumed to be eavesdropping chuckled as well, just in case she’d said something worth laughing about.

“You know, I heard of these wonderful shoes from our guests a while back. *Stilettos*. I’d love to wear a pair, although I wonder if the points can be sharpened further?”

“I shall inquire at the first opportunity.”

Magnolia sipped her drink, eyeing Tyrion Veltras, scion of one of the Five Families of Izril, and technically, as powerful as she was. Perhaps more or perhaps less. For all those in the room, that was a question whose answer would be worth its weight in diamonds.

“Why don’t you dance with him, Ressa?”

“No.”

“Even if I ordered you to?”

“Even then.”

The pair’s casual banter might have attracted Tyrion’s attention, or he had simply heard the announcement. Magnolia sighed as she saw him glance around and felt his piercing gaze settle on her face with very little love. She returned the glance, with no love at all.

“He’s coming over. Duty bound to offer greetings, no doubt.”

“Shall I attempt to stop him?”

“Best not to risk an altercation, Ressa. Besides, he’s not as weak as he used to be. You can’t push him around and I rather fear he could lay waste to this entire room with all the artifacts he has on him. Allow me to employ a gentler touch.”

She walked over towards Tyrion. A group of [Lords] and [Ladies], noticing Magnolia Reinhart and Tyrion Veltras approaching each other and realizing they were in the way, immediately shuffled at speed to one side. There was little love lost between the two, and so it was with stiff formality that Tyrion bowed to Magnolia and she gave him the slightest nod.

“Lady Magnolia. I am honored to greet you on this day.”

“Lord Tyrion. I’d rather hoped you would have eaten something ghastly and exploded by now, but fortune hasn’t been kind to either of us, has it?”

The man’s eye twitched a bit, but he covered the motion by passing a gloved hand over his mouth. He was dressed much like Ressa, which was to say, all in black. He was also a head taller than Magnolia, which annoyed her because it left a crimp in her neck every time she talked to him.

“You are as thorny as ever, Reinhart.”

“Only to you, Tyrion. Don’t tell me this was the crisis that pulled you away from your estates?”

The man glanced impassively around the room.

“I considered it an important matter. I should have expected you would be present, however. You seldom missed such events as I recall.”

“I never do.”

Magnolia retorted, noting the people watching and listening to their conversation on the peripherals of her vision. She knew many people here had Skills or an artifact that allowed them to eavesdrop. Not that she feared saying anything important—but it would be just like Tyrion to say something devastating without a second thought. Information was currency here, and someone might make their fortunes based on a sentence carelessly let slip.

Tyrion Veltras studied Magnolia, not looking too pleased to see her. He really did think it was a [Lord]’s duty to greet her as a peer. How tiresome.

“How long has it been since we’ve met?”

“Four years, I believe. I was deeply saddened to hear of the passing of your wife. I hope your two young sons are in good hands.”

He stiffened at that, and the metal cup in his hand *bent*. Magnolia saw fury in his eyes and saw Ressa moving towards her quickly, a hand in her dress. Magnolia stopped her maid with a flick of a finger.

“What do you mean by *that*?”

Magnolia remained cool as she stared up at Tyrion.

“Exactly what I said. That was a sincere comment from the heart.”

He paused, and she could see him visibly readjust, grow calmer. He bowed his head slightly.

“Then I shall take it as such. My apologies.”

A [Lord] does not question a [Lady]’s word. Magnolia sighed out loud.

“You really haven’t changed. As pleasant as this is Tyrion, I think I shall go walk barefoot on glass shards for a more delightful change of pace.”

“Until we next meet, Reinhart.”

They left it at that. Magnolia walked back and Ressa met her in moments.

“That was fun.”

“It will become even more enjoyable in a second.”

“Oh, what now?”

“Left.”

Ressa’s warning came a moment before another person swept towards Magnolia. A lady and a man, both dressed in bright clothing, came striding towards Magnolia. Both she recognized, and it was with a smile that Magnolia greeted them. A smile the lady did not return.

“Bethal! How wonderful it is to see you!”

“Magnolia.”

The [Lady] gave her the most perfunctory of curtsies and the man bowed to her slightly. Magnolia kept smiling, but she noticed the expression on the other woman’s face. It was not happy.

“You seem upset, Lady Bethal. May I ask why?”

The woman replied curtly.

“I do not know. Perhaps you could explain the hooded figure that my guards found in my gardens two days ago. They gave chase and slew the intruder when they fought back. An [Assassin], as it turned out. Did you have anything to do with this, Magnolia?”

There was a feeling in the air that grew strong as Bethal spoke. Not just a feeling. An aura that surrounded the woman. The word for it was spiky. It was as if invisible edged blades filled the air—it wasn’t just a feeling either. People around the two ladies began moving away at speed, but Magnolia simply smiled.

“Lady Bethal, if I sent an [Assassin] after you, would I be so foolish as to send *one*? You and I have not quarreled and I do believe we are friends. That [Assassin] was not mine, believe me. In fact, I am quite grateful you killed him. Or her. Or it?”

The [Lady] studied Magnolia’s face.

“Her. She was a human.”

“I am pleased you came to no harm. And I trust neither did your guards?”

Bethal hesitated. The dangerous aura around her faded. She smiled at Magnolia and laughed lightly. It was as if her fury of a second ago had

never been there, and the effect was disconcerting if you had never met Lady Bethal before.

“Of course not! How silly of me. Here I was worked up about the issue, while my dear husband assured me you would never have anything to do with that!”

“Not for all the gold in Baleros.”

“Then let me say how wonderful it is to see you!”

The two traded light kisses on the cheek, Bethal exclaiming over Magnolia’s dress. The woman turned to the man standing beside her.

“And of course you know my husband.”

“[Chevalier] Thomast. Of course! How are you, Sir Thomast?”

“Very well, my lady Reinhart.”

The elegant man in the doublet bowed and kissed Magnolia’s proffered hand. She smiled at him and then turned back to Lady Bethal.

“Have you seen Patricia? I should welcome her before the arguing starts.”

Bethal shook her head, pursing her lips.

“I have not seen her. But her daughter is over there.”

She pointed. Magnolia turned and saw a young girl laughing demurely with some other girls her age while they eyed the dancers in the center of the room. Magnolia smiled as her eyes fell on one with flowing brown hair.

“Ah, young Eliasor. She must be eight now.”

“Nine.”

Ressa murmured as she and Thomast nodded to each other. Magnolia sighed.

“Ah, to be that young. I won’t go over and scare her, Ressa. Perhaps you can go and ask a servant where Patricia—”

She broke off. Someone was speaking. In fact, every head in the room turned and almost all of the conversations ended at once. Because the

person who was speaking could be heard by everyone who wore a jeweled brooch, as if they were standing right next to the speaker.

“The King of Destruction has returned. Are we supposed to simply pretend this isn’t an issue and chat idly? Let us discuss this crisis already!”

Magnolia looked for the man who’d spoken. She recognized one of the more aggressive [Lords], a proper war hawk, who’d grown impatient waiting. Many people were frowning at him, but his standing probably hadn’t been damaged by speaking the thoughts on everyone’s mind.

By custom, the absent hostess should have initiated the debate. But once it had begun, voices began speaking. Usually it was only one or two voices at once, but the conversation en masse could become an indecipherable hubbub as well. It was to this Magnolia listened, letting the first speakers make their points and reserving her words for when they mattered.

“If you must bring the subject up, Lord Relt, then begin with the facts. *Has the King of Destruction returned?*”

“Every report says so. Unless you have no spies in that region?”

“My informants claim he was awake months ago.”

“If it’s a game of guessing when he awoke, I won’t bother. But this is the first moment in which he’s taken action similar to the past.”

Someone spoke up sharply. Magnolia saw Lady Wuvren snap the handheld fan she carried. The *crack* made all the listeners wince.

“He destroyed a nation and beheaded its [Queen]! The Quarass of Germina is *dead* and the capital lies in ruins! And the King of Destruction is already marching on Hellios! What are we to think, if not that the King of Destruction is destroying nations again?”

Silence. Someone coughed and then spoke.

“It *was* a war of retaliation.”

Wuvren rounded on the speaker.

“A war? It was a massacre! He destroyed the enemy army in a pitched battle in a single day!”

“After six nations sent an army after him.”

“Yes. If that doesn’t confirm the King of Destruction has returned, I imagine few things will.”

“So then, your point?”

“The question was whether the King of Destruction has returned. I would say he most emphatically has, and he hasn’t changed.”

Relt spoke into his stone, overriding the next speaker. Magnolia winced and wished there was a way to lower the volume the enchantment produced.

“No, he has not. And he must be stopped now, or he will once again destroy nation after nation and threaten our shores.”

“Surely not!”

This speaker was another [Lord]. He was a minor one, but he held his ground as Relt glared at him.

“You don’t fear the King of Destruction, Lord Halast?”

“I don’t fear a man on another continent, surrounded by nations which have every reason to want him dead.”

“Those are the same thoughts that let him engulf all of Chandrar last time!”

Halast spoke curtly.

“Last time we didn’t know what he was capable of. Now everyone knows the danger posed by the King of Destruction. The nations will unite, and defeat him. He doesn’t have his armies any longer, and as far as I know, only a few of his vassals have rejoined him.”

“He has his Seven—”

“Four now. And I’m told that Amerys is still residing in Wistram.”

“She hasn’t joined him?”

“Or perhaps the [Mages] have convinced her to stay. Either way, the King of Destruction is not as dangerous as he was.”

“That was what was said *last time*. If you’re foolish enough to believe he won’t succeed—”

“He slew one ruler. Not a [Queen]! It was the Quarass of Germina, hardly royalty.”

“What’s a Quarass?”

Magnolia opened her mouth to respond, but Lady Bethal by her side spoke into her stone first.

“The Quarass is as important as a [Queen]! She is a tribal leader—”

“A [Chieftain] is hardly comparable to a [Queen].”

Bethal’s voice could have cut iron.

“The *Quarass* is a position revered and acknowledged across Chandrar, Lord Luden. She, along with three other leaders are considered part of the Shield Kingdoms, which hold sway over a great deal of eastern Chandrar, if only politically. Once upon a time, the Quarass and the other Shield Kingdoms were each powerful empires, capable of challenging *Dragons*. Her death will cause ripples throughout the entire continent!”

“Well spoken.”

Magnolia murmured to Bethal as the conversation lulled for a bit and Lord Luden flushed red. Bethal smiled at Magnolia and whispered back. She didn’t have a finger on her stone so her words weren’t carried to the others.

“I do pay attention to women I admire.”

At that Magnolia had to cough so her eye roll wouldn’t be noticed. As far as she understood, the Quarass was not a woman to be admired, at least, not by anyone who thought honor and decency were more than words.

The argument began heating up. It was always like this, and Magnolia listened with one ear as she watched the [Lords] and [Ladies] who’d come to the gathering argue about what was to be done about the King of Destruction.

“We could send gold to a nation—”

“Gold hardly buys arms and soldiers. A small nation can only do so much.”

“What about the Emperor of Sands?”

“What about him?”

“He’s at war with the King of Destruction.”

“If he is, it will be a long time before they meet. And if he triumphs, I hardly imagine an [Emperor] would be an improvement over the King of Destruction.”

“I am saying we *must* act in some way.”

“Are you proposing to send an army across the sea?”

“Utter foolishness!”

“I am proposing we act in some measure, even if it is to condemn the King of Destruction—”

“A signed treatise? What use would that be?”

“A united front—”

“—won’t be part of any declaration—”

“—funding a mercenary company from Baleros—”

“—see what Wistram has to say—”

“May I offer a course of action?”

The voice that interrupted was deep, low, and booming. He silenced every other speaker. And Magnolia’s head turned. She turned, searching the crowd and saw the speaker standing by a pillar, alone. She hadn’t seen him before, but upon hearing his slightly nasal, deep, *deep* voice she knew who—and what—had to be speaking.

Quite carefully she turned and hissed to her [Maid].

“Ressa, why didn’t you mention the Minotaur to me?”

The woman shrugged.

“I assumed you’d spotted him.”

“I *would* have eventually, but it helps when you point such important people out!”

The Minotaur was speaking now. He was dressed in a suit tailored for a Minotaur, emphasizing his physique and biceps. Magnolia eyed it—not in

appreciation as Bethal was doing—but thoughtfully. Here was a Minotaur who had been financed to attend such events. Odd.

“I hesitate to interrupt, but I have been sent by my [King] to address this auspicious gathering. My role is as an emissary. The House of Minos is prepared to go to war against the King of Destruction, that he might never threaten the world as he did in the past.”

Gasps rang out across the room. Magnolia’s brows shot together as a low murmur sprang up throughout the room.

“If that’s the case—”

“The armies of Minos? Will they sail all the way to Chandrar?”

The Minotaur spoke, carefully touching the stone.

“My [King] is prepared to send an army capable of defeating the King of Destruction. However, he understands such an act would be considered a declaration of war by many kingdoms. She has tasked me and others to approach other assemblies and request formal support.”

“In what fashion?”

Magnolia spoke sharply into the stone. She sensed heads turning. The Minotaur bowed to her.

“We would ask for a written treaty allowing us to sail without hindrance, and a small contribution to our army. Arms or gold would allow us to ready ourselves for battle.”

“So you are approaching us as mercenaries, is that it?”

The Minotaur paused. It was a touchy word for them, but Magnolia was watching his face across the room for his reaction. She saw him give her and the others a polite smile which revealed nothing.

“We would like to consider it more a manner of honor than anything else. To defend peace, our people are willing to fight. It is an offer made in good faith.”

And that cast her into an unfavorable light for questioning him, didn’t it? Magnolia narrowed her eyes as people began to express relieved support.

“I’m sure we could offer some small token of thanks—”

“An open-ended agreement from our houses should not be an issue. What say we put it to the vote?”

Magnolia didn’t know if she wanted that. But she could sense the mood in the room and it was immediately swinging towards this unexpectedly convenient solution. Too convenient. She glanced at Tyrion. Magnolia knew if she voted against the resolution—and she didn’t have a solid reason to—she would be able to pull quite a few votes with her. But it would only work if another scion of the Five Families were present, and in this gathering there was only Tyrion.

He was watching the Minotaur warily. But when it came to a vote, Tyrion voted to support the Minotaurs, and so did Magnolia.

Ressa frowned at Magnolia as the discussion went on as to how much to give the Minotaurs and how to word a declaration that the humans of Izril were against the King of Destruction.

“A problem, milady?”

“How much do we know about the Minotaurs, Ressa? They’re always fighting their enemy down around their isles—but recently?”

Ressa thought.

“A few engagements at sea. Their failed war with Baleros around fifteen years back. A war with Terandria which Izril participated in twenty eight years ago. Numerous skirmishes...”

“They tried to take over the world once. But then, which race hasn’t?”

Magnolia studied the Minotaur, frowning. Ressa stared impassively at him. The Minotaur was giving nothing away. He was a trained [Courtier] or some similar class, Magnolia had no doubt. And that was odd. She’d never seen a Minotaur in a diplomatic function.

“You think this is a trick?”

“Possibly, but it’s probably a trick in the sense that they’ll honor their word and then demand something else when they’re in a good position. The lands that belonged to Flos, perhaps. That would give them quite a bit of territory, which is what the Minotaurs always wanted.”

“Do you believe we should not have voted for them?”

“I think we’ll have to wait and see. And I might have to see about finding some spies willing to visit the islands...although they would stick out like a sore thumb.”

Magnolia sighed as the conversation came to a close. The people in the room seemed generally relieved by the resolution, so she decided to stir up the pot. There was more than one reason she’d come here today.

“Before you leave, [Lords] and [Ladies] of Izril, let me put another important matter forwards.”

Heads turned apprehensively towards Magnolia. She looked around the room, watching the Minotaur out of the corner of her eye.

“Have you all forgotten that there is a Goblin Lord raising an army just south of the High Passes?”

Silence. Then someone spoke.

“We are aware, but that is a Drake issue, isn’t it? With all respect Lady Reinhart, I had heard the Drakes were taking care of the issue.”

“Oh? Are you so certain they will defeat the Goblin Lord?”

Magnolia’s tone was icy. The Minotaur wasn’t changing his expression at all. She cursed inwardly.

“They’ve sent two armies to fight him. Together they should crush a Goblin Lord.”

“And if he escapes? A Goblin Lord is one step away from a Goblin King. And I have heard different rumors as well. Or has no one else heard of a troubling tale? That of a so-called Goblin Great Chieftain? One who fought *with* the last Goblin King in the war?”

The Minotaur *twitched* ever so slightly at the mention of the Goblin Chieftain. Around the room Magnolia could hear some people gasping who hadn’t heard the rumor.

“A Great Chieftain? Is that a class?”

“*With* the last Goblin King? Why would we have not heard of a Goblin like that?”

“To support the Goblin Lord? If that’s the case—”

“Are you suggesting we send an army ourselves to deal with the Goblin Lord, Lady Reinhart?”

That last question came at Magnolia. She broke away from eyeing the Minotaur who’d gone back to impassively watching to smile at the speaker.

“That is the question, isn’t it? Do we send an army? The Great Chieftain is on our lands. I believe he must be eradicated no matter what, and I am sure you are all in agreement. As for the Goblin Lord—”

“Let the Drakes deal with him.”

Someone cut in. Only one person would dare. Magnolia turned to Tyrion, but he returned her gaze without blinking. He spoke confidently as all eyes turned towards him.

“Even if the Goblin Lord destroys both Drake armies, let him go. Unless he comes north—and if he does, he will most likely destroy Liscor—we will benefit.”

Outraged voices rose.

“Destroy Liscor? If he heads north, our southernmost cities will all fall as well! Esthelm was already destroyed! Are you suggesting we let that happen to every city in the area?”

Tyrion’s voice was calm.

“Esthelm did fall, but the people have retaken the city. They fought off another of the Goblin Lord’s armies.”

“*What?*”

Shock echoed through the room at this. Magnolia ground her teeth together. Tyrion *would* know about Esthelm. She knew what he was doing but she couldn’t stop it. The man continued calmly.

“Our cities can defend themselves. They knew the risks of being closer to the border. If the Goblin Lord comes north, we will muster an army to defeat them. And if he does come north, he will have done more damage to the Drakes than we. And that is all to the better, once war comes.”

“We do not *need* war with the Drakes! We need allies, not more enemies!”

Magnolia snapped into her speaking stone, but the mood was against her. People were in favor of leaving the Goblin Lord alone, especially if it meant trouble for their southern neighbors. Tyrion abandoned the conversation, job done. Magnolia tore the gemstone off her dress and stormed towards him.

“You are an idiot, Tyrion Veltras.”

“And you don’t see the danger the Drakes pose, Reinhart.”

His voice was cold as he spoke to her. Tyrion eyed Ressa and the [Maid] gave him her coldest stare which didn’t faze him an inch. Magnolia took a deep breath and tried not to kick the man.

“Sending an army to pointlessly kill thousands of Drakes every few years does *not* help this continent, Tyrion. What do you expect will happen if you win this time?”

“If we beat them at the Blood Fields, we’ll take Liscor. We just need the upper hand and we will push past the High Passes. They’ve held it this long, but the Goblin Lord is the opportunity we need.”

Tyrion stared calmly at Magnolia. She opened her mouth to tell him *Drakes* were not the enemy, when someone screamed.

Her head whipped around. Someone was standing at the double doors. A man in black, with a sword in hand, dripping blood. His face was wrapped in a black shroud, and he was unmistakably an [Assassin]. He shoved the [Head Butler] aside, and the man fell, a wound in his chest. The [Assassin] lifted something with his left hand and threw it.

A head flew into the center of the room. It landed wetly on the ground. More people screamed. Magnolia stared at the head and then saw the blur.

“*Magnolia!*”

Ressa leapt, but it was Tyrion who caught the dagger. He swatted it out of the air with a gloved hand, interposing himself between Magnolia and the [Assassin]. She blinked at him.

“Did you just save my life, Tyrion Veltras?”

He turned to her as the [Assassin] began to flee.

“A [Lord] does not deal with underhanded murderers and plots. If I kill you, it will be out in the open.”

Magnolia nodded. Then she seized Ressa, who was guarding Magnolia’s back.

“*Find the others.* There must have been more!”

Ressa hesitated.

“I should guard—”

“Tyrion is here. Go!”

The [Maid] hesitated, and then became a blur that leapt towards one of the windows. More people cried out as glass broke and Tyrion stared after Ressa with narrowed eyes.

“The [Assassin] will escape. Is that your plan?”

Magnolia was breathing a bit heavily. She saw people running after the [Assassin] now the shock had ended. The Minotaur was running, although he could hardly hope to catch the killer.

“No. He won’t get away.”

A voice rang out above the shouting. A man strode forwards, rapier in hand. Thomast, Lady Bethal’s husband.

“*[Affair of Honor]!*”

The man in black had reached the doors. But he paused, mid-step when Thomast used his Skill. The Chevalier’s voice rang throughout the room.

“*Turn, murderer.* There can be no retreat until this matter is settled by blade.”

Magnolia saw the [Assassin]’s shoulders slump. He turned, and the Chevalier Thomast strode towards the man in black, rapier in hand. The room parted for the two to meet.

Magnolia did not watch the assassin die. She strode over to the head on the floor pushing aside the people who’d formed a wide circle around it. Magnolia stared down at it as a [Lord] and a female adventurer inspected

the head carefully, neither actually touching it. The [Lord] looked up, saw Lady Magnolia, and stood up to bar her path.

“Lady Reinhart, please stay back. The head may be warded or enchanted to do further harm upon being touched.”

“Then check. But I wish to see the deceased.”

“Stop wasting time.”

Someone pushed past her. Magnolia turned and saw Tyrion. He strode into the circle of onlookers and despite the adventurers’ protests, bent and picked up the head by the hair.

Something *flashed* on his hand. A ring blazed and then the light from within faded. Tyrion inspected the head and then turned it to face Magnolia. She felt a lurch in her stomach, but controlled the feeling. Instead of fainting, retching, or staggering away as some of the people behind her were doing, she simply sighed.

“Ah, Patricia.”

The dead woman’s head was white, drained of blood. Her features were contorted in horror, but it was her face. Magnolia would have known it anywhere. She had been a friend of Magnolia’s.

And now she was dead.

Tyrion stared at Magnolia.

“Is the [Assassin] another one of your plots, Reinhart?”

“No, some enemies of mine seem to want to kill me. And my friends too, it seems.”

Magnolia spoke automatically, while one phrase flashed through her mind again and again.

The Circle of Thorns.

Tyrion shrugged.

“This is no business of mine.”

He turned, and handed the head to a [Lord] who nearly dropped it. Tyrion strode out of the room as Thomast bent to wipe his blade on the dead assassin’s clothing. A capable killer he might have been, but Magnolia

knew there were few who could match someone of the [Duelist] class in a one-on-one bout.

In the end, Ressa returned empty-handed. The head disappeared, and the room was filled with shock and fear. Magnolia ignored the eyes turned towards her and the whispers, and found Lady Bethal with her husband.

“Lady Bethal. Thomast. Thank you for disposing of the killer.”

The man’s eyes were shadowed as he bowed.

“It was my honor and duty. But I regret Lady Patricia’s death.”

“Yes. And she had no husband. So there is another matter which must be dealt with now.”

Magnolia turned and Ressa pointed her silently towards a group of girls, one of whom was weeping uncontrollably. Patricia’s sole daughter, Eliasor, tried to curtsy when Magnolia approached her, but the woman waved that away.

“No formalities now. Eliasor, I am sorry that your mother was killed in such a heinous way. But now that she is gone, there is something that must be done.”

She touched the gemstone Ressa handed her and spoke into it loudly, cutting above every other voice in the room.

“Ladies and lords! Lady Patricia’s life was cut untimely short! However, her daughter, Lady Eliasor still lives. She is now the head of the Melissar family. I bid you all welcome her as a peer!”

There was a pause, and then by her side, Lady Bethal curtsied to Eliasor. The girl stared at her, wide-eyed, and then at Lady Magnolia as she did the same. Around the room, the [Lords] and [Ladies] remembered their duty and bowed or curtsied, acknowledging Eliasor.

It was a painful sight, to see the girl try to respond as tears still ran down her face. Magnolia spoke to her more quietly.

“I know this is hardly the time to think of such things, but you are your family’s sole heir now, Eliasor. If you wish it, I will send my own guards and [Maids] to assist you in the weeks to come.”

The girl opened her mouth, choked, and kept crying. Magnolia paused.

“I fear your mother’s death was my fault. Lady Patricia was one of my confidants, a trusted friend. She had a place in my circle, and I hope that one day I may offer you the same. But I swear to you, Eliasor, I will find the people who ordered your mother’s death. And I will kill them all regardless of where they hide. You have my word on that.”

“Thank you—Lady Reinhart.”

Magnolia nodded down at Eliasor. She hesitated, and then walked away.

“Lady Bethal, Lady Pryde, Lady Wuvren, Lady Zanthia, to *me*.”

They came out of the crowd, people parting to let them pass. Magnolia looked at some of the foremost [Ladies] of Izril, and nodded towards the doors.

“Let us leave Eliasor to her grief. We must talk.”

They strode out of the room, people parting to let them pass. Magnolia’s face was carefully blank, and she kept the emotions tightly held in her chest.

“It’s too harsh, leaving her to govern her entire house like that. Must she really become a [Lady] in the moments after her mother’s death, Magnolia? Couldn’t it have waited a week? Or a month? Or years?”

Bethal murmured as they walked down the corridor. Lady Zanthia, tall and old and willowy, but tough as a tree, nodded, looking sympathetic. Magnolia’s voice was a bit sharper than she had intended as she replied.

“What would you have me do, manage the girl’s affairs for her? Or let a distant relative or friend do it? How would she ever become a proper [Lady] then? No. No, she must either rise to the challenge or fail alone. Our help can only be that. Help.”

She walked on, speaking as the fire built in her chest. The gall of it. An [Assassin], sent to kill at a gathering of the nobility.

“This is *Izril*, ladies. Not Baleros or Chandrar, where war is a part of life. Not Rhir, where struggle is part of life. And not Terandria, where monarchs dictate who lives and who dies. Here we fight with words and thorns. We know peace, but peace with Drakes and Gnolls is bloody. We must struggle alone. Alone, even when we are together. To survive. And those who cannot survive, die.”

Heads rose. Four of Magnolia's escorts, her entourage that she seldom made use of, stared at her. Magnolia looked around.

"Summon your most trusted protectors, your own soldiers, my ladies. Bethal, your husband and your Knights of the Petal will be needed. The same goes for the rest of you. I had planned to tell you after the meeting, but there is a war going on. I am reforming my entourage. Prepare to move at once and together. No one else will die. No one."

They nodded and began to stride towards their carriages as their servants ran to meet them, their guards armed and wary. Ressa walked to stand next to Magnolia. She looked at her mistress, and saw unshed tears in Magnolia's eyes. But Magnolia's voice was steady and she made no mention of them when she spoke to her [Maid].

"It seems my enemies are far bolder and resourceful than I would like, Ressa. I need an army, and not just one fielded by my entourage."

"What are you intending?"

Magnolia took a breath. She knew what she had to do, but she didn't like it.

"It's time to go back to the family estate. My grandfather has an army, and I will have it from him."

"Didn't you swear you'd never go back unless you were dragged kicking and screaming?"

"Broken promises. A friend is dead, Ressa. One of my people, one of my allies. I'll have an army, if I have to beat that old man to death myself."

"Well then, I shall begin sending [Messages]."

Magnolia nodded. She felt tired, distracted, and worried. She stared back towards the ballroom, and felt a tightness in her chest. She never knew what to say to children. She should have said something. But nothing had helped when her mother had died. Magnolia turned away and stared out into the fading sunset.

"I fear it's going to be a very busy spring, Ressa."

The maid just nodded in reply.

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She lived in Liscor, at least for the moment. It was a home away from home, of sorts. But in truth, her real home lay far away. Someday she wanted to go back to it, but for now she did her best. That was what she did. Her best.

It was a curious thing, but despite her presence in the city for a relatively short amount of time, many people knew her name. Of course, not all of those people liked her. But she was noted. She stood out, even among her prolific species.

She was unique. And famous, in her own small way. There were people across the continent who'd heard of her, or heard of things she'd done. Important people knew her name.

It was not that way for the world. Few cared about her, having their own struggles and battles to worry over. The news of the King of Destruction's return eclipsed anything she might do now or in the immediate future.

And yet, one of the most powerful males in the world knew of her. He desperately wanted to meet her, though he'd never laid eyes on her before.

Because she could create wonders. If the people of this world believed in miracles, they would have called them that. But these were natural things to her. The incredible things she could do weren't mere acts of magic, but something deeper.

She had only one real class. Only a few people knew her true nature. To the rest, she was part magic, part enigma. But she changed Izril, changed Liscor, changed people by her very presence.

Her class was [Thaumaturge]. She worked wonders. Her name was Xrn.

And she was sitting in a small dirt room in the Hive of the Free Antinium underneath Liscor. And she was not happy.

"It's not that I'm angry, Klbkchhezeim. I'm just disappointed."

She was talking to another Antinium, a slimmer version of the Workers who filled the Hive, and one with only two arms. Klbkch sat hunched over

in his chair, avoiding looking at Xrn.

That was difficult for anyone not used to her. Xrn stood out from every other Antinium in Liscor's Hive, possibly the world. Her carapace was azure, not brownish-black. And her eyes *shone* and swirled with countless colors, a magical storm whirling behind her faceted eyes.

The colors were tinged green and orange and pink now, the colors that reflected her irritation. The Prognugator of the Grand Queen of the Antinium, known by her enemies as the Small Queen, Xrn, stared pointedly at Klbkch, but he didn't respond. She made a sound that sounded like a sigh crossed with a *click*.

"I understand you have your duties. It cannot be easy to manage a Hive while attempting to combat numerous threats from this dungeon, *and* maintain your position as this—what did you call it?—[Guardsmen] in the city. Attending to the group sent by the other Hives must weigh heavily upon your time."

No response. Xrn looked pointedly at Klbkch. The colors in her eyes deepened, growing darker. Klbkch knew that was a bad sign. She wasn't just irritated.

"And yet, I note you apparently had quite a lot of time to spend eating and entertaining yourself at an inn. So much time in fact, that you were able to create your own *presents* and receive two yourself."

Klbkch hunched his shoulders. His voice, when he spoke at last, was defensive.

"It was Christmas."

"A Human tradition."

"It was an important social event that fostered—"

"Klbkch. I am not questioning your use of time. I am simply asking why you haven't included *talking to me* as part of your activities."

An unpleasant silence followed her words. The Antinium didn't usually beat around the bush, so after a moment Klbkch looked up and nodded slowly.

“We’re talking now. I had wished to delay our conversation, Xrn, because I anticipate the outcome and believe it will not be favorable.”

“Oh?”

Xrn shifted slightly. She had only two arms, like Klbkch, and she had been folding them in a fashion she’d picked up from Humans. Now she uncrossed her arms.

“What is your fear?”

Klbkch exhaled inaudibly. He stared at his old...friend? Was that the word for her? Perhaps. She was more than that, and yet not a friend. A sister, perhaps. But that was inadequate.

They were Centenium, he and she. He had been known as Klbkch the Slayer during the Antinium Wars, but his origin lay far before that time. Back then, he and Xrn had known each other. Fought together. But after all this time, he wasn’t sure he knew her anymore.

So Klbkch chose his words carefully.

“My conclusion upon learning you had arrived to personally oversee the achievements of Liscor’s Hive was that you were here to order me to return to the Grand Queen.”

If Xrn had eyebrows she would have raised them. Since she did not, her mandibles twitched, and a yellow element appeared in the miasma of lights in her eyes.

“An interesting thought. Why would you believe that?”

“The Grand Queen’s desire to have me act as her Prognugator is not unknown to me, Xrn.”

“And you believe I was sent for that purpose alone?”

He shook his head.

“Of course not. But she would not have sent you unless she had ulterior motives. I know her beliefs regarding my Queen’s work with Individuals.”

“She is not alone in that regard. But your work *has* achieved much.”

Klbkch nodded. Modesty was also a foreign concept to the Antinium.

“A start. It is something the Antinium have never created, these... Individuals. I trusted you would know their worth. But that does not detract from my point. Did the Grand Queen not send you with instructions regarding me, Xrn?”

Instead of answering his question, Xrn stared at one of the walls. There was nothing to stare at but dirt, yet that in itself was telling. Klbkch had visited the other Hives. He knew some were built of stone, others fortified, the walls hardened. The other Hives were grander, larger, and the Queens had their own elite soldiers, and had modified their Workers and Soldiers accordingly. Yet this Hive was where the hope of the Antinium lay, Klbkch was sure.

“Do you know what I have been doing this last decade, Klbkch?”

He shook his head.

“I assume acting as an aide and advisor to the Grand Queen.”

“That is my duty, yes. Go on.”

“Fighting? Defensive duty? Negotiating with other Queens and Prognugators?”

Xrn sighed.

“You are unoriginal.”

“I prefer not to guess. Speculative statements are a time-consuming endeavor that I attempt to refrain from partaking in. You remind me of my partner in that regard.”

“The Drakes have some things to teach us.”

Klbkch nodded.

“Yes. They are quite adept at wasting time.”

“True.”

Xrn fell silent again. She raised her hand, and Klbkch saw her perform a trick she'd often do when she was thinking. As Xrn stared at her hand, miniscule spires of ice appeared, freezing over parts of her carapace. Fire chased ice and the resultant water and steam swirled—not upwards, but around her hand and down her arm, gathering, turning into lightning which

crackled and struck stone fragments which melted and gathered, turning into magma—

Klbgch looked away. He stared at Xrn. She truly hadn't changed. Just as before, he couldn't read her expression. Xrn tapped her fingers onto Klbgch's simple wooden desk and the whirling elements spilled onto it, burning and freezing the sturdy wood. Klbgch watched calmly. A new desk would not be an issue. The Hive's funds would allow him to buy a thousand desks in a moment if he needed to.

"I have been busy, Klbgch. Not always with tedious work. It has been a while, but I trust you recall the first war against the Crelers?"

Klbgch nodded. He clenched one hand unconsciously.

"I recall."

"A truly costly series of encounters. Well, in the time since I have participated in several offensives. At one point we were forced to aid the Armored Antinium in combat against Giant Moles. I trust you are familiar with them?"

They were worse than Crelers, in some ways. Klbgch's mind flashed back to the sight of a huge creature, seventeen times the size of the largest Soldier, tearing its way through a tunnel, devouring Workers and chewing through Soldiers in a single bite—

"I have encountered them. And I am familiar with the battles of which you spoke of. My Queen debated sending a force to assist in the fighting."

"There was no need. But such encounters certainly detracted from our war strength. If we had chanced upon them or unearthed the Caverns of Consumption during the last war, things would have gone far worse for us."

"I am not familiar with the Caverns of Consumption, although I recall hearing a report on the subject. What manner of danger was this?"

"Parasites. They infected over forty percent of the Silent Antinium's Hive before we could eradicate them."

Klbgch nodded slowly. He didn't shudder, but he felt as though something was crawling underneath his carapace at the thought.

"A terrible setback."

“So it goes.”

Xrn shrugged again as if the termination of nearly a half of a Hive’s Workers and Soldiers was of no concern. She looked pointedly at Klbkch.

“We have gone through far worse battles. That the Hives struggle with each emerging threat—and ones in the future as the Hives continue to expand—is telling in itself.”

The Revalantor’s head bowed.

“Yes. It is regrettable.”

The Small Queen watched him carefully. She was observing Klbkch, just like he was analyzing her. Strangers sat together.

“It matters not. The Hives are growing despite these setbacks. But through these challenges, I have reclaimed almost all of my lost levels.”

Klbkch looked up in surprise. He hadn’t thought about it. It was only a dream for him to regain his former strength, as weak as he now was. But Xrn was different. She had only ever died *once*.

“If that is the case, the Grand Queen must surely be elated at the news. Having such an asset would also influence her opinion on declaring war a third time.”

“Possibly. But I have not informed her of my leveling for a long period of time.”

Klbkch froze.

“Why?”

Again Xrn ignored his question. She looked around Klbkch’s small room again. He had only a few objects in it. His chairs—chair; they’d had to get another one for Xrn to sit—his desk where he stored important files, and a new addition: a coatrack. It had no coats on it, but a black and red scarf had very carefully been wrapped around one of the arms.

“Klbkch, I came here against the Grand Queen’s wishes. She would have preferred to let one of the other two Prognugators lead the group. Tersk, most likely. She is aware of Pivr’s...flaws. His numerous flaws, I should say. The Grand Queen dislikes that pestilential larvae as much as I do.”

Klbkch nodded, his tone souring. On this, he, Xrn, and the Grand Queen were in agreement.

“I cannot fathom why the Queen of the Flying Antinium deems his actions appropriate.”

“She is erratic. But no Prognugator created since coming to the continent has been anywhere close to adequate. You know this, Klbkch. You and I—and perhaps Wrymvr—are the only competent Prognugators. The Grand Queen would rather you return to the Hive, but she is aware of your commitment. With that said, she did not want me to leave either.”

“So why leave?”

“Because it was the only excuse that would allow me to visit you. In truth, I do not believe the Grand Queen cares whether your Hive has created Individuals or not.”

That was an unpleasant surprise to Klbkch, and one he knew would deeply upset his Queen. He put his hands on his table and scooted his chair further under his desk.

“...I was under the impression our efforts were being recognized, even if they were not completely accepted by the other Hives. We have worked for years for this purpose. Surely you see the merits?”

“Tersk does. Perhaps his Queen will. But the Queen of the Silent Antinium doesn’t care. She didn’t send an envoy. The Grand Queen makes the motion, but the other Queens follow her lead. Klbkch, they may recognize the use of Individuals, but they do not believe such beings are necessary for the Hives.”

“They are *wrong*.”

Klbkch was surprised at the emotion in his voice. He stood up.

“If the Grand Queen does not believe, tell her about Anand and Belgrade. Tell her about Bird, and of Garry’s class! Individuals may be costly and irreplaceable, but they can contribute far more than a battalion of Soldiers if used the right way. The Antinium need leaders.”

“They would say that is what Prognugators are for.”

“You mean like Tersk and Pivr?”

Klbgkch's voice was cold. He nodded towards the open doorway. The other two Prognugators were still in the Hive. Tersk was no doubt observing, or aiding in battle against monsters from the dungeon. Pivr... was probably being a nuisance.

"They are not what the Hives need. Tersk is acceptable, but he is hardly high-level. And if he falls, an army is dependent on a distant Queen to control it. *And they are not suited to war.* The Soldiers need a real leader to take command. Multiple leaders, so they cannot be picked off like they were in the last two wars!"

He was emotional, he knew. But Klbgkch had argued that very thing so long ago, and to hear the Queens had not changed—yet it was Xrn who was nodding.

"You are correct. But the Queens will not accept your statement, Klbgkch. They did not in the past and their minds are difficult to change, with the exception of yours. The problem is, they did not know Galuc. Or rather, the version of him the Queens believed in was false. They do not think copies of him have morale. They treat the Soldiers and Workers as unbreakable, beings without the capacity for despair or fear."

Klbgkch nodded. He had known Galuc. The Queens had known of him as well, but not like Klbgkch. Galuc the Builder had felt great emotion. But he had never broken, never given in, even at the end.

Xrn went on.

"However, their notion is largely correct. These...fragments have his strength of mind. Yet they are only flawed replicas of the original in body and personality. The Queens believed that there was no merit in imbuing fragments with individual identities, if that was even possible."

"As did you."

Klbgkch leaned forwards in his chair, remembering. He stared hard at Xrn.

"You were of the same mindset and voted against the attempt. Have you changed your mind?"

Xrn shook her head.

"I did not vote against the measure for that reason."

The Antinium never called each other liars. There was no point, no reason to. Klbkch clicked his mandibles together sharply, the equivalent of taking a deep breath.

“Explain.”

“I believed there was no reason to give the dead names. I thought we would conquer this continent in the first war, and then the second, and fulfill our duty years ago, without creating individuals. I was wrong.”

There it was. Klbkch sat down hard. Xrn had just justified all the work he’d done, conceded the argument that had torn them apart for over a decade.

“I was correct.”

She smiled at him, lifting her mandibles. The Antinium did not hide the truth when they were wrong.

“You were.”

But then she grew silent, pensive. She stared at Klbkch’s desk, which was engulfed in a war between the elements. Xrn waved her hand, and the fires, the ice, the water and lightning—all vanished in a moment, leaving behind a distinctly weathered wooden surface behind.

“You were right, Klbkch. These individuals are valuable. If we go to war a third time, they may well change the outcome of the conflict.”

Klbkch opened his mandibles, eagerly pressing the second part of his old argument.

“*If* we need to go to war again. As I have said—”

“Yes, if. If we must take the continent, oust the Drakes and Gnolls and Humans to begin with. I am starting to come around to your thinking on that point as well.”

It was everything Klbkch had wanted to hear, what his Queen had wanted to hear. And yet—why was Xrn talking to him here and not telling his Queen this? He paused.

“Why? Why do you believe this now?”

Xrn paused a third and final time, and Klbkch knew they were coming to the heart of the matter. His blood raced a bit quicker throughout his body.

“...Do you know how long it has been since we came to this continent, Klbkch? No—do not answer. It is a pointless, Human way of asking. I know. Over two decades. And in that time, we have rebuilt our Hives. And yet, Klbkchhezeim. And yet. After all this time, no new Queens have been born.”

Klbkch’s heart paused. He looked carefully at Xrn.

“None?”

She shook her head.

“Not a one.”

Klbkch tried to come up with a response.

“The Queens have time. If they continue their efforts to discover—”

“That is not the problem, Klbkch. It is not that they are trying to create new Queens and failing. It is that they have *given up trying altogether*.”

The words knocked Klbkch back like a blow. He sat back in his chair hard and nearly overbalanced.

“No.”

Xrn’s eyes were steady, darkness and hints of blue and gray the only colors.

“Yes. They have not tried.”

“But surely they know—”

“They do not want to try. Or they are afraid to. This entire time I believed the Grand Queen was prioritizing the issue, as you were. But I have learned she has given up attempting to recover that knowledge. There are no new Queens, Klbkch.”

“But there *must* be!”

Klbkch sat up, outraged, afraid. He stared at Xrn.

“We cannot expand if there are no new Queens! The Hives have a limit to expansion, especially with only one Queen and no sub-Queens attending

her! And without a Unistasis Network our armies—”

“Are flawed. Slow. I *know*, Klbkch. I have argued with the Grand Queen on this point countless times. But she refuses to try. She is afraid.”

“Of what? Failure?”

“Success. Of being replaced, I think. Or perhaps—no, I cannot fathom all of her reasons. But it is enough that you know.”

It was. It changed everything Klbkch had assumed about the Hives. He lowered his head and spoke quietly.

“Let me talk to my Queen. She can try—”

“Against the other Queen’s directives? She has no resources. They were denied to her by the Hives. I am surprised she managed to alter your form, let alone resurrect you.”

Klbkch hesitated. This was a deep secret he was about to share, but Xrn was laying her secrets bare. He felt obligated to do the same.

“The necessary reagents can be...obtained. It is difficult, but possible. If I purchase from [Alchemists], perhaps—”

The Small Queen was shaking her head.

“That is an unlikely outcome, Klbkch.”

He felt a spark of anger. It was hot and fierce. But it was burning on despair.

“What then? Are we to give up on our future?”

“Not at all. Why do you think I am *here*? No, Klbkch, it is because of our future that I have come here, using the Individuals as an excuse. In fact, they are the reason I have come. If not, I would still be in the Grand Queen’s Hive, trying to create Queens on my own.”

“*You* tried—”

“Repeatedly.”

Xrn’s voice was tired. She traced a finger on Klbkch’s desk, leaving a trail of fire behind.

“I burned what I created. I cannot do it. Perhaps your Queen can, perhaps not. You should tell her either way. But my idea is more direct. We must have more Queens, Klbkch. We must stop running, stop focusing on pointless battles here. We have been here for two *decades* and barely a handful of Hives exist. This was not the plan.”

“No, it was not.”

Klbkch felt tired. They had failed. But Xrn’s eyes lit up, and a spark of white, golden light filled them. Hope flashing in the darkness.

“We cannot stay here, with flawed Queens who remain fragmented. With no hope of rebuilding our people. We must return home, Klbkch. We must recover our lost knowledge.”

“You don’t mean—”

Xrn’s gaze nearly blinded Klbkch. The purest blue light of unwavering determination blazed in the depths, mixed with gold and the orange glow of fury.

“Yes. We must go back. To Rhir.”

In the minutes that followed, Klbkch thought over a thousand different responses, from denial to incredulity to acceptance. In the end he simply asked one word.

“How?”

Xrn smiled. She stood up, and placed hands on Klbkch’s desk. The wood began to change, and small figures of colored lights began to rise out of the wood, marching, assembling as she spoke.

“A strike force. A few thousand Soldiers and Workers—elites if they can be acquired as well. But most importantly, a group of Individuals that can lead and fight on their own. Remember the expeditionary units of the past?”

Klbkch nodded slowly. How could he not? He had led so many, as had Xrn...

“Yes.”

And then he put the pieces together. Klbkch’s mandibles clicked together sharply.

“So *that* is your reason for coming here. You want the Individuals my Hive has produced—”

“More if possible. And higher level, of course. I can secure the specialist elites of other Hives, perhaps persuade other Prognugators like Tersk. He may be persuaded to listen, despite not knowing the truth yet. But I still need those with levels. You would not be enough, Klbkch, weakened as you are. And Wrymvr—”

“You sent Zel after him. If he dies, or if Shivertail dies trying to avenge General Sserys it will be war—”

“Perhaps. But I think Shivertail would win, and it would not be war if I speak to the Grand Queen. I think a death might bring Wrymvr back to his senses, which is why I told General Shivertail.”

Klbkch paused.

“Why? What is wrong with Wrymvr?”

Xrn looked calmly at Klbkch.

“I think he has gone insane. So has his Queen. But that is not the issue, Klbkch. The Queens, the Hives—all the Antinium on Liscor are *not* the issue. Going to Rhir and coming back with a Queen or the knowledge of how to create one—only that will save us all.”

Klbkch looked at her. He put a hand on his sword’s hilt, gripping it tightly.

“You still think they’re alive, don’t you?”

“They swore to fight for a thousand years if that was what it took. I believe they have continued to do battle, believing in us. We failed them, Klbkch. Now we must go back.”

“Across the ocean. Where we lost everything.”

Xrn nodded. She and Klbkch paused, remembering. Remembering the disaster, the storms—her fingers twisted and water splashed down, but the shimmering figures were safe, protected by a bubble of air on the tabletop.

“We learned from our failures. This time we will learn to sail, and I have studied spells to guide us across the ocean. If we land on Rhir—”

“We will have to fight our way down there. Past the Blighted King and the Demon King.”

“If necessary.”

“And then—then if there are still survivors, we take a Queen?”

“A younger one with the necessary knowledge, yes. If we could escort her back—”

“The odds are terrible.”

Klbgch stared at the plan Xrn had outlined on his desk. She nodded.

“But it is possible, Klbgch. More so with your Individuals. The [Strategists] you have helped to create—Belgrade and Anand—they will be invaluable. I was intending to use the Prognugator copies the Grand Queen had created instead, but these Individuals are far more original, far more *capable*.”

Klbgch stared at Xrn in shock. He’d met the Prognugators sent to guard her. They were created as Ksmvr had been, but like him they were incomplete, deeply flawed versions of what they should have been.

“*You* encouraged her to repeat those experiments?”

“It was my only option at the time. This is our only hope, Klbgch. I will pursue it with any means at my disposal.”

Xrn was not defensive. She simply explained. And she looked at Klbgch, hope shining in her eyes.

“It will take much preparation, Klbgch. Years—perhaps another decade if a war breaks out. But this is the only way I see to survive. I place my plan in your hands. Will you join me, or will you stay here?”

Klbgch paused. He stared at his desk, and then looked up at Xrn. He felt emotion building in his chest, and felt the two swords hanging at his sides. He shook his head slowly. Xrn stared at him, crestfallen. But that wasn’t what Klbgch meant.

“No. It will be sooner than that. We will make the journey, Xrn. In time. With more than just Antinium. Perhaps—yes, perhaps there is more we can add to your plan.”

Golden fire. Xrn's eyes lit up like the first time Klbkch had seen the sun. She placed a hand on his shoulder as he stood and joined her. Klbkch stared at her, and realized he was more whole than he had been in a long, long time.

Two of the Centenium stood together. One had changed in body, and the other not at all. But they were different than they had been. Different, and yet not. Because they remembered. They hadn't come to this continent to live and die here. The knowledge was a scream in Klbkch's soul. The Queens knew they had not come here to simply dig Hives and create mockeries of what they had been! They had come here to go back! They had retreated to fight!

"We will return."

It was a whisper, a promise. Xrn looked at him.

"You said more than Antinium? Do you actually have allies you would trust with our secret?"

"At least one."

Klbkch thought of Ryoka as he turned to Xrn.

"But even if we do not have allies, we will have more Individuals."

"How? I am still uncertain about how your Hive produces them. Your Queen did not give me a straight answer."

"That is because she does not know. And I do not either."

Incredulity, a greenish strip of color languidly weaving through the gold.

"How can you not?"

Klbkch smiled. He sat back down, motioning for Xrn to do the same.

"There is hope. Things have changed. These recent developments, the Individuals, all of it stems from one person. If your plan is to succeed—if we are to have hope, we must focus on one person."

"Who?"

Xrn stared intently at Klbkch. He looked up, towards the ceiling, towards the sky.

“It all starts and ends with a young Human girl. You have met her. Her name is Erin Solstice and she comes from another world...”

Erin Solstice sat in her inn and stared at the Antinium in front of her. She was a Level 30 [Magical Innkeeper], the sole proprietress of The Wandering Inn, her home, and currently, very confused.

“Let me get this straight. You like birds.”

Sitting across the table from her, Bird the Antinium nodded. He was sitting awkwardly on the edge of his chair, a short bow and a few homemade arrows sitting on the table. Erin eyed both. Apparently the Antinium didn’t use ranged weapons much, and so Bird had taken it upon himself to manufacture his own gear.

She looked back at him.

“But you *kill* birds. I mean, you hunt them.”

“Yes. I kill birds.”

“But you like birds.”

“Yes.”

Erin paused. She scratched her head and someone hurried over to the table.

“Mister Bird? Another glass of raw eggs?”

“Yes, please.”

Bird turned and his mandibles raised as Lyonette carefully handed him a mug filled with raw eggs. Five cracked eggs. Bird had requested it specially. Lyonette smiled at Bird, and then hurried away before Bird began to drink.

Erin watched, only slightly grossed out as Bird delicately let a glistening yolk drop into his mandibles. He clicked them together appreciatively.

“I am very grateful. Do I offer more coins now? I have many.”

“No, you can pay after. Just let me get this straight. You like birds, but you *kill* them.”

Bird nodded.

“Yes. Shooting birds is enjoyable.”

Erin stared at him. It wasn't that she disliked Bird, one of the Individual Antinium who lived in the Hive under Liscor. In fact, she really liked him. He, along with four other Antinium—Belgrade, Anand, Garry, and Pawn—had been the only survivors of a group of Antinium Workers who'd given their lives to protect her when a group of undead had attacked her inn.

It was just that Bird was weird. Even for an Antinium he was weird. Pawn thought he was weird, Anand and Belgrade agreed, and Garry—well, Erin hadn't gotten a chance to chat much with Garry, but the Antinium had definitely mentioned Bird's weirdness when he'd helped Erin out at the Christmas party.

She was just trying to figure him out. And it wasn't working. Erin rubbed at her head.

“Okay, okay. You like birds. But you kill them. Uh, Bird, I don't know how to say this, but generally, you don't kill things you like.”

The Antinium looked confused. He lowered his mug.

“But what is the point of killing something you don't like?”

Erin opened her mouth. She closed it. She put her hands in her hair.

“You know what? How about we go back to what you do every day.”

Bird nodded amicably.

“I shoot birds.”

“...That's it? I mean, don't you do anything else? Do you have duties in the Hive like Pawn, or Anand or Garry?”

He paused, thinking.

“I contribute resources to the Hive, mainly in the form of edible foodstuffs. On a daily average, I provide approximately 261% the value of the average Worker, thus justifying my existence. I am also considered to be

a war asset of undetermined value, and have special qualities deemed important to the Hive at this moment due to my Individual nature and levels. Thus, I am permitted to act autonomously due to my unique class.”

Erin stared at him. Sitting underneath the table, Mrsha raised her head and smacked it on the bottom of Erin’s chair. Lyonette’s head turned as she scrubbed at a dirty table. Bird looked around and shrugged.

“That means I can go out and hunt birds. Revalantor Klbkch said so.”

Erin glanced around her inn. It was empty, aside from Mrsha and Lyonette and Bird. Her regular guests were all out. As adventurers (and one [General]), they didn’t hang around the inn much. She took a deep breath.

“Got it. You shoot birds. That’s cool.”

“I hunt all day. Sometimes all night.”

“Right. And do you do anything with the birds you shoot?”

“I bring them to the Hive.”

“Oh. That’s all?”

Bird hesitated. He glanced around the room and lowered his voice. Erin leaned forwards at Bird’s insistence. He looked guilty as he confessed to Erin in a hushed tone.

“Sometimes...I eat the birds I shoot instead of bringing them to the Hive.”

Erin stared at him.

“Okay.”

“When I am hungry.”

Bird clarified. He looked guilty. Erin nodded slowly.

“So you cook them?”

“No.”

“Wait, you eat them *raw*?”

“They are crunchy. And not crunchy in places.”

“But *raw*—”

Erin looked down as Mrsha poked her head out from under the table. The Gnoll didn't seem to have a problem with Bird's eating habits. The Antinium nodded.

"Sometimes I throw them on a fire. The taste is different. So is the color."

Erin had a feeling Bird's method of cooking was *literally* throwing dead birds onto the fire. She took a breath.

"Okay, but you know you could cook them properly, right? You know, chop them up? Roast them? Bake them?"

"If I bring them to the Hive they are processed into paste. It does not taste good."

"Processed—you mean that muck Pawn says all the Antinium eat?"

Bird nodded. Erin tried to imagine how a dead bird would be turned into that and shuddered.

"Okay, maybe you have the right idea. But if you cook things—"

"I do not have any Skills."

"But you could learn—actually, wait. I have a better idea. Why don't you bring your dead birds to me, and I'll cook them for you? Free of charge!"

Bird stared at Erin as if she were a genius.

"You would cook birds for me?"

She grinned at him.

"Yeah! And I can make them very tasty, Bird. I can add a bit of lemon, some salt and pepper—make some gravy—you won't ever go back to eating raw birds when you taste my cooking!"

The Antinium didn't salivate as far as Erin could tell, but Bird's body language told her he was extremely interested in this offer. But then he drooped and his antennae sagged.

"Ah. But I do not have many coins. Not enough to eat cooked birds all the time."

"That's not a problem!"

Erin hurried to reassure the downcast Bird. She thought and pointed to a bag which the Antinium had brought into the inn. It was tied tightly.

“You hunt a lot of birds each day, right Bird? Even in the winter?”

“I shoot many of them, yes.”

“Well then...if you give me a few birds, I’ll cook as many as you want to eat! That way, I get something and you get something! How’s that for a deal?”

Bird considered this.

“This is a good deal. I will accept. Thank you, Miss Erin.”

She beamed at him. Bird reached for his sack.

“I have birds now. Can I give you some?”

“Well of c—”

Erin paused as Bird untied the knot holding his sack open. Underneath the table Mrsha yelped and across the room Lyonette gagged. The [Princess] put a hand over her mouth and Erin nearly fell out of her chair as Bird pulled a dead bird out of his sack.

It was dead. That wasn’t the issue. The issue was how long it had been dead *for*. The smell was—Erin stared at the dead bird and saw things *moving* on the corpse.

“Here is one bird. Can you cook it?”

“Put it—put it—”

Erin was trying not to throw up, back away, and avoid Bird’s outstretched hand at the same time. Mrsha fled as something dropped onto the table and *wriggled*.

“Put it back!”

Bird did so, looking confused. Erin made him tie up the sack—and then throw it out into the snow before she tried to explain the difference between a freshly-caught bird and a rotting one that had been sitting in the sack for two weeks.

“So I must obtain fresh birds?”

“Yes! Doesn’t your Hive say that to you too?”

“Freshness does not matter. Those birds are acceptable for processing.”

“They—you’re joking.”

Bird stared at Erin. She stared back. She thought about the wriggling things and covered her mouth.

“Okay. Wow. No wonder Klbkch eats here instead of at his Hive. Bird? I need fresh...birds. You can preserve them in ice, and bring them to me. But if they’re old, you have to bring them to the Hive, okay? And you can’t...can’t mix old birds with new ones, alright? I’ll explain all of it to you, but you can’t bring really rotten birds into my inn, okay?”

Bird nodded, looking serious and clearly not comprehending Erin’s line of thought at all.

“This is an important issue?”

“Yes!”

Erin Solstice stood at the table and scrubbed hard with soapy water after Bird had gone. She avoided the wriggling orange maggot until a paw reached onto the table and grabbed it.

“Mrsha!”

She whirled and the white-furred Gnoll fled, the squirming maggot held triumphantly in one paw. Erin went to run after her, but Lyonette got there first. Erin heard the two having a one-sided argument as she turned back to cleaning the table.

“No, Mrsha! You can’t have it. No, you can’t—don’t *lick* it! See how bad it tasted? Now, give it to me—no, no, you can’t put it with Apista. She’s in a shell and I don’t think she wants company. Just give it to—just throw it outside in the snow, far away, okay? There’s a good girl.”

Erin turned her head and saw Mrsha scampering out of the inn. She also saw Lyonette carefully arranging a large bowl set in the middle of a table in

the far corner of the inn. She was tending to Apista, her pet, making sure the bowl was filled with royal jelly and warm enough.

Erin could appreciate Apista, although she hated wriggling things in general. Technically, the bee larvae that Lyonette had adopted as a pet was also a maggot, but at least this one was...bigger? Well, it was part of the inn now, and that meant it was as good as family. Even if it was butt ugly.

But Apista had grown on Erin—literally. After the few days since she'd returned to her inn, the larvae had begun metamorphosing into a hardened shell, at first just an indistinct blob, but which was taking on the appearance of a bee day by day. It would hatch soon, Erin felt, and then...

Well, Lyonette had the [Beast Tamer] class, and so she'd be able to control it. Or so Erin desperately hoped. But in truth, Erin had no idea what Apista the Ashfire Bee would be like when she finally emerged from her pupal state.

Apista. Now there was a good name. In truth, Erin had been holding out for Beeyonce, or Pudge, but Lyonette had settled on Apista, and Erin had to admit it made sense. Not that anyone besides Ryoka would recognize the Latin name, though.

Was it odd to own an inn and have a [Princess] working as your barmaid? Was it odd having a white Gnoll child—a furry hyena like species that lived in tribes—running around holding maggots? Was it a bit disconcerting to sit with an Antinium, one of the insect-like people who lived underground, and talk about hunting birds?

Maybe, but Erin had gotten used to it long ago. Now she squeezed the rag she'd been using into her bucket and looked at Lyonette.

“How's Pudg—I mean, Apista doing, Lyonette?”

“Good, Erin. I think she's healthy. I mean, I can sort of sense it, thanks to my Skills!”

Lyonette looked proud as she tilted the bowl to show Erin the hard carapace of the growing bee. Erin nodded.

“You really like classes, don't you?”

“I'm a Level 3 [Beast Tamer] now! And a Level 4 [Carer]! I leveled up in both classes last night!”

The girl's chest puffed up with pride, and Erin smiled at her.

"That's really great. You're leveling up in a different class every day, or so it seems."

"I just want to learn it all. I know one class is best, but—"

Lyonette's face fell. Erin studied her. Lyonette was a [Princess]. She'd told Erin as much herself. But she was a runaway princess, and a failure too, if what she hinted to Erin was right. Apparently, she was only Level 5 in the [Princess] class, despite having been one her entire life.

"You know what, Lyonette? I think you're a great [Barmaid]. You've only been working here for a few weeks and you're already Level 9! Once you get to Level 10—well, I'd better give you a pay raise."

"You don't have to—"

"I should! I totally forgot to pay you this entire time. And you do so much work—it's no wonder you're leveling like crazy."

Erin grinned at Lyon as the girl's face went red. It was remarkable how much she'd changed from the haughty, angry girl that Erin had first saved from freezing to death in the snow. Erin glanced at the windows as Lyonette busied herself with Apista's bowl, still blushing furiously.

"Speaking of which...I think we're all set until dinner, Lyonette. We've got firewood, water, groceries...why don't you and Mrsha have a break? You can take her into the city!"

Lyonette looked up with a grateful smile.

"Really? You're sure? I could stay and mind the inn if you need me to —"

"We're fine. No one's coming back for a while, and if they do, they know I'm going to be out. Plus, I've got some soup sitting in the kitchen just in case. You two deserve a break!"

Erin waved an airy hand as Mrsha came bounding back into the inn. The Gnoll's white fur was covered in snow and Lyonette went to chase Mrsha as she tracked it onto the newly cleaned floor. Meanwhile, Erin went into the kitchen to get some coins for Lyonette to spend.

Liscor. It was only ten minutes' walk away from the inn, and the city was filled with Drakes, Gnolls, and a good deal of Humans. It was the place to be if you wanted to have fun, mainly because there wasn't anywhere else to go to in the open, rolling landscape that surrounded the city.

Both Erin and Lyonette had a history with the city, although Erin's relationship was a great deal more positive than Lyon's. In truth, the girl had been kicked out of the city for stealing and burning down a shop.

It wasn't that Lyonette's exile had been lifted, but thanks to Zel Shivertail, one of Erin's guests who also happened to be a hero among his people, the Drakes, in practice Lyonette could go into the city whenever she liked.

"Here's some money for the week."

Erin went over to Lyonette with a handful of coins. She counted them out into the girl's hands, giving her mostly bronze and silver. But Erin's fingers paused as she picked up a substantially larger coin, which wasn't silver but shone with brighter radiance in the light.

"Oh—sorry. Wrong coin."

Lyonette blinked as Erin took the coin out and put it in her belt pouch.

"What's that? It's too big to be a silver coin."

"It's...a secret. I'm trying to figure it out myself."

Erin smiled at Lyonette as she handed the girl the other coins. Lyonette blinked at a gold coin glinting at her and opened her mouth to protest. Erin shushed her.

"It's for Mrsha! Buy her something nice and maybe get her another toy when you're out shopping."

"But what are you going to do?"

"I'm going to do business!"

"If it's shopping, I can buy it. I think Krshia's okay with me—"

"No, no. I have it! You have fun. That's an order!"

Erin shooed Lyonette out the door, Mrsha joyfully bounding about in the snow. Then she went over to the counter under her bar and began

pulling out large bottles filled with various colors of liquid. Erin found a sack, grabbed the rest of the smaller denominations of coin for change, and walked out of her inn.

“Time to get to my part-time job.”

The city of Liscor was filled with people. Drakes and Gnolls, primarily, but Humans had come seeking wealth recently. They weren't exactly welcomed with open arms by the city's natives, Drakes, who resembled giant lizard-people and hated being called lizards, and Gnolls, who, unlike Mrsha, had brown fur, black fur, grey fur, reddish-orange fur—but never white fur.

Erin walked down the streets, smiling at passersby, looking at the open architecture of the Drake's buildings, and being tempted by food vendors frying grilled meat, steaming liberally spiced vegetable skewers, or making one of the city's new favorite fast foods—hamburgers.

Soon enough, Erin reached a large building along the main street. It had a decent flow of foot traffic, Humans, Gnolls, and Drakes all entering the double doors. What set these individuals apart was that unlike the normal type of pedestrian, the people using this building were generally armed. They were adventurers, and wore everything from leather armor to polished plate to enchanted robes.

The Adventurer's Guild in Liscor wasn't used to so much business, and so Erin knew that if she went inside to see her friend Selys, she'd probably have to wait for a long time as the [Receptionists] tried to keep up with all the adventurers coming in and out. But Erin wasn't here for a social visit. Instead, she put down the heavy bag she'd filled with jars in the snow and rubbed at her shoulder. Then Erin took a deep breath and raised one of the jars into the air. She was holding a spoon in the other hand.

“*Samples!* Get your free samples! Magical soup! Anyone want a sample?”

Heads turned. People stared. Erin tried not to blush as she waved a jar of bright red-purple liquid at the crowd. She felt silly, but she was used to that feeling. The important thing was doing something, trying something.

“You there! Mister Gnoll? Sorry, Miss Gnoll...want a sample? It’s free! Try my defense soup! Anyone want a taste? It’s magical! It works!”

People passed by, but some began to stop. They approached, staring at the jar Erin was waving. She heard people asking questions and uncorked her jar and offered a spoonful around. People backed away, but they kept watching. Slowly, a crowd began to gather. And the commotion alerted the Adventurer’s Guild, because soon a trio of Drakes pushed out of the doors.

One of them had bright yellow scales, another light green scales, and a third had dark green scales with a white pattern that reached from her tail up her back, although her clothes made it so only her tail was visible.

The Drake with bright yellow scales was looking around.

“What’s the commotion?”

The one with dark green scales pointed at Erin, and all three [Receptionists] looked over. The one with yellow scales rolled her eyes and twitched her tail dismissively, but the one with light green scales smiled when she saw Erin’s face.

“It’s that Human.”

“The crazy one? I mean—the one with the hamburgers?”

“Shush, Drassi! That’s my friend. I told you two about her.”

Selys grinned toothily at Erin. She’d drawn a crowd in minutes. There were Drakes that Selys knew in the crowd, people who didn’t like Humans. But they stopped because it was Erin, *that Human*, the one they knew on sight even if they didn’t know her name.

The crowd had formed a circle and was staring at the colorful jars Erin was waving around, but no one had stepped forwards yet. Selys waited for a volunteer. Because as much as she liked Erin...

She wasn’t going to try the soup herself. At least, not until someone else had done it first.

A volunteer stepped out of the crowd after a few seconds. It was a Drake adventurer from the Guild. He looked hesitant, but his companions were egging him on. They were a group of five, and he had been chosen as a scapegoat.

“Um, Miss?”

Erin turned to him with a big smile.

“Hi! Do you want to try a sample?”

“A...sample?”

The Drake looked uncertain. Samples were not a tradition in this world, but Erin gave him a big smile and explained.

“I’m showing people my cool new soup! It’s magic, and I’m selling it in my inn. Do you want to try it?”

The Drake gulped. He had black scales and he was actually a bit shorter than Erin.

“What—what does it do?”

Erin pointed proudly at the red-purple jar in her hands.

“This is defense soup! I’m calling it that. Or maybe thick skin soup? Naw, that sounds bad. Anyways, it makes your scales tough!”

The Drake eyed the jar with increasing skepticism as Erin dipped the huge spoon—ladle, really—into the jar and lifted it. He glanced at his friends and at the crowd, but it was too late to back out.

“I just drink it—”

“Yep! Don’t worry. It’s sweet!”

The Drake gingerly flicked his tongue out and tasted the liquid. His eyes widened.

“It is sweet!”

The crowd of onlookers watched as the Drake slowly gulped down the soup. It didn’t look that tasty, and the Drake made a face and muttered about mushrooms, but then he’d swallowed it all. They waited, but the Drake stood looking vaguely queasy, but not noticeably different.

The adventurer coughed and glanced at Erin.

“Do I have to wait or does something happen?”

“It should be taking effect right now! Okay, now hold on a second—”

Erin put down the jar and spoon. When she came up, she was holding a kitchen knife.

“Now I stab you.”

The circle of onlookers suddenly got a lot wider, very quickly. The black-scaled Drake backed away, claws raised.

“Whoa. Miss Human, I didn’t volunteer for that!”

“Don’t worry! It won’t hurt a bit! Thanks to my soup, I won’t be able to cut you.”

“I’d—really rather not risk it. I can’t feel a change.”

“Come on, just a poke—”

Erin advanced with the knife. The Drake backed away.

“No, no. I’m not going to be cut. Sorry, but find someone else.”

He turned, much to the crowd’s vocal disappointment. The Drake began walking back towards his friends, shaking his head as they motioned him to go back. Erin stared at his back for a moment. Then she sidled over to him. Erin raised the kitchen knife—

And she stabbed him in the back.

“*Aaargh!*”

He fell to the ground and rolled around. Selys’ friends put their claws over their mouths and Selys covered her eyes, but she could still hear the adventurer screaming.

“*She stabbed me! That crazy Human stabbed me!*”

He shouted at the crowd as he thrashed about.

“Quick! Call the Watch! Get a [Healer]! I’m going to *die*! I’m going—”

The adventurer was feeling at his back, for the spot where Erin had thrust into his back. He suddenly froze as his claws landed on the spot.

“Oh.”

Everyone stared at him. The adventurer looked around. Though his scales were black, Selys could see a slight red blush appear around his face. He got up very slowly and brushed the snow off of his gear. He sheepishly looked at Erin.

“I’m uh, okay.”

“Of course you are, silly!”

Erin laughed. She stabbed the adventurer in the stomach. Hard. He yelped and grabbed at his stomach, but now everyone could see there was not a speck of blood. There *was* a slight scratch on his scales, but that was all.

“And now, here’s my trick!”

Smiling, Erin showed the knife to the crowd, and then pulled a carrot out from the sack she’d brought. She tossed the carrot up and cut it in half with a quick slash of the knife. She caught the two pieces.

There was a brief pause, and then the crowd burst into applause. Beaming like a ringmaster, Erin bowed.

“Thank you! Anyone want to try? Free samples! I promise it doesn’t taste bad!”

“Ooh, me! Me!”

Someone shouted from the back of the crowd. A huge figure Selys recognized pushed his way forwards, shouting.

“Watch business! Clear aside! I’m a Senior Guardsman I’ll have you know—hey Erin!”

“Relc?”

Erin stared at the grinning Drake [Guardsman]. He stared down at the jar of red soup, licking his lips.

“Is it good?”

“Um, yeah! Want some?”

Erin hesitantly offered Relc a spoonful. He slurped it down.

“Sweet!”

Erin stared at Relc as he began flexing his muscles, poking at his biceps and trying to see if the potion had taken effect.

“Aren’t you supposed to say ‘move along, nothing to see here’?”

He looked confused.

“Why would I do that? I want to watch! Hey, does your potion help if you get hit really hard?”

Erin hesitated. She hadn’t tried hitting herself over the head in her limited stress-testing of her defense soup.

“...Maybe?”

“Let’s find out!”

Relc walked over to the adventurer and punched him in the stomach. The black-scaled Drake doubled over, but it was a mark of the soup’s effects that he was able to stand back up and take a swing at Relc, which the Drake casually dodged.

Erin’s soup might have been an unknown quantity, but apparently Relc’s punching power was not. That opened the floodgates, and soon Erin had emptied one jar of her defense soup or as Relc wanted to call it—Scale Soup.

“Because it gives you another set of scales, get it? Look! I can barely cut this guy’s scales with the knife!”

“Ancestors! *Stop!*”

Relc was chasing the black-scaled Drake around with the kitchen knife as Erin opened the jar filled with her blue, thick, warming soup.

A young human woman pushed her way to the front of the crowd to taste this first. She was apparently in the black-scaled Drake’s party, although she wasn’t helping him. She had a curved sword at her waist, which looked like a katana to Erin’s eyes. The girl stared at the young woman and smiled.

“Want a taste?”

“Sure.”

The young woman made a face as she downed the soup, but in a few seconds she was blinking and shedding clothes. She was actually giving off steam in the cold air, which made several children clamor to have a taste.

“So you’re selling this soup? It’s a potion for travelling, right?”

“And fighting Snow Golems! I bet you could give them a hug and they’d melt!”

Erin beamed. Some of the other adventurers were nodding. One, a Gnoll with several scars showing through his fur, eyed the soup appreciatively.

“I could go swimming in the coldest lake with this soup, yes? And the Scale Soup—it is like a Bark Potion, or something similar.”

The other adventurers were nodding. The young woman with the katana looked at Erin appraisingly.

“How much?”

Erin hesitated. She took a deep breath and tried to project confidence. This was it. Time to make the sale, Octavia style!

“Two gold coins. *But* if you buy in bulk I’ll throw in a fourth soup for every three you buy. And I’ll—”

“*Two gold coins?*”

The people around Erin exclaimed and she sagged. She couldn’t speak fast enough.

“Okay, okay, I *could* do one and a half—”

“You’re charging *one* and a *half* gold coins for this soup?”

The female adventurer stared at Erin. The girl wavered.

“I could do one coin...but I wouldn’t make much of a profit. Look, if you buy a lot of soups, then *maybe* I could—”

Selys couldn’t watch. She elbowed her way quickly to Erin.

“What they mean is, why are you selling it so cheaply, Erin? This is way too good to sell for so little!”

“Oh!”

The innkeeper brightened up. She scratched her head.

“Because...I can?”

The crowd looked at Erin suspiciously. She wavered, and cracked.

“Okay, if I sell a lot, I’ll earn a lot, right? If I charged like eight gold coins, I wouldn’t sell enough!”

“But the going rate for a Bark Potion is *seventeen* gold coins.”

Someone pointed that out. Erin’s eyes went wide.

“Whoa. Really? That’s...a lot.”

The adventurers were still staring at Erin. One of them, a far shorter Human who was rather squat, pointed at Erin.

“You said soup. Does that mean you aren’t an [Alchemist], Miss?”

“No, I’m uh, an [Innkeeper]. But wait! I’m actually a [*Magical Innkeeper*] so it makes sense! I have a Skill that lets me cook magical food!”

“I’ve never heard of magical food.”

Erin waved her hand frantically as people began to grow increasingly skeptical.

“It’s true! I’ve got a Skill! I can cook food up and make it magical if I use the right ingredients! It’s like alchemy, I promise! But I can fry food, make it into a soup—it’s a lot faster, and a lot less messy than alchemy!”

“And you can make stuff like this?”

An experienced female Drake adventurer pointed to the half-empty jar of soup Erin was holding. It was still hot, still steaming despite having been on Erin’s shelf for six days. Erin nodded, smiling. The adventurer thought about that for a second.

“That’s not fair.”

Someone else nodded.

“You’ll run out every [Alchemist] in the city if you sell your products that cheap!”

Erin looked shocked and hurt.

“I wouldn’t do that! I can’t make healing soup—I mean, I’ve tried and haven’t figured it out yet. And my soups aren’t as good as really high-level potions. Octavia—she’s an [Alchemist]—said so.”

“Okay, but you’re still selling swords for salt. You’re telling us there are no disadvantages to your soups compared to potions?”

The adventurer with the katana pointed to Erin’s jar. The girl hesitated.

“Well...”

Every head stared fixedly at her, especially those who’d had her soup. Erin scuffed at the snow.

“...There is an expiry date on my soups. They don’t uh, last forever like potions.”

People exchanged glances. Erin looked guilty. Selys cleared her throat.

“That’s it?”

Erin nodded.

“My soups last the longest, but I can only make the best ones last about a week. And if I cook something else up, like a sauté, it goes bad in a few hours. Unless I keep it in my inn. It doesn’t go bad there because I have a Skill.”

The Gnoll adventurer peered at the jars.

“How does it go bad? Does it explode or turn into a fungi or turn acidic?”

“No! Nothing bad happens! Well, you throw up a lot.”

Again, more incredulous looks pinned Erin.

“That’s all?”

Erin wavered. This was getting into some personal and troubling territory she’d rather not remember.

“Not...exactly.”

The crowd tensed again, ready for the horrible details. Erin took a breath and turned red.

“You get...bad poops sometimes. Really bad poops.”

“Bad poops?”

Erin nodded.

“*Really* bad. Like...you could pull down your pants and hit a target ten feet away with it.”

The crowd shuddered. Erin shuddered too. *She* hadn’t been the one with that reaction, thankfully. But Mrsha had drank half of one of the expired soups and—

“And then there’s throwing up. Sometimes it’s just bad, but I had one reaction where I threw up in all different colors.”

Relc stopped chasing the black-scaled Drake around.

“Ooh, like a rainbow?”

Erin thought about that. She shook her head.

“Exactly *not* like a rainbow. That definitely wasn’t what it looked like.”

“But that’s all? That’s the only side effect? Your potions—I mean, soups—go bad after a while and they make you sick?”

“Yup!”

Erin stared down at the ground. Octavia made lying about her products sound so *easy*. But Erin couldn’t do it. Maybe she could sell her potions for one gold coin after all?

In the crowd, the adventurers traded glances. The group with the black-scaled Drake nodded at each other, and the young woman with the katana cleared her throat. Erin looked hopefully at her. The adventurer felt at her belt pouch.

“...Do you do discounts for repeat customers?”

A while later Erin walked back out of Liscor, a bag with two empty jars and a spoon carried over one shoulder. Her belt pouch was plump, and Erin was debating how to celebrate tonight. Maybe with a hotpot with a lot of

meat? Mrsha would like that. Everyone would like that, but Mrsha would especially.

Erin already had orders for tomorrow, and she was going to have to talk with Octavia about ingredients for her cooking tonight. But for now she just enjoyed the sensation of profit. It made her feel...golden.

It was another normal day for Erin, filled with event and unevent in equal measures. It was a good day, and one she could smile about as she walked back to her inn. But she kept staring northwest, towards a road that was mostly abandoned. No one was travelling in the cold, partly due to the weather, partly for fear of Goblin attacks. But Erin kept looking, kept searching.

“Come on, Ryoka. What’s taking you so long?”

She murmured under her breath, her smile slipping just a bit. Because despite her doing so much, despite everything, what Erin was doing was waiting. She was waiting. Waiting for a friend.

And far away, a day’s journey from Liscor, closer to Celum in fact, a young woman was running down the road. She didn’t know about the magic door, and so she was running down side roads, through the snow, wary of monsters, bandits, and tree roots in the snow.

She was tired, cold, hungry. A Frost Faerie flew beside her. Ryoka Griffin ran towards Liscor. She was coming back, returning after such a long time. It felt like months had passed, but Ryoka was nearly there. There was only one day of hard running left.

In truth, Ryoka would have gotten to Liscor sooner, but Reynold had run over a group of bandits and broke an axle.

4.08 T

In the depths of Liscor's Dungeon, past rooms filled with deadly traps, magical ward spells and places where foul monsters made their homes, a skeleton sat on the ground. He held his head in his hands.

Literally in his hands. Toren's skull stared blankly ahead. The skeleton sat with his back against a wall in a corridor without light. He wasn't dead; he was undead. And he didn't move.

Nothing approached him. Dark shadows slithered or walked or rolled or oozed or floated or teleported or crawled or moved in some other fashion past him, taking no notice of the skeleton. Nothing tried to kill Toren, which was an oddity in this dungeon. But the monsters and other things didn't bother with Toren.

Not out of fear or lack of malice; there were things down here that felt no fear and relished the chance to hurt anything, even the undead. But they passed Toren by because he just sat and didn't move. To most, he would simply be another skeleton, and there were more than a few in the dungeon. But Toren's eyes burned dimly in their sockets.

He was still alive.

This is how it happened.

Toren had been approaching Liscor with the band of undead he had taken from Esthelm. He had been furious, plotting revenge against those *stupid* Goblins, the Knight and the Humans, and especially against Lyonette. She was a given in any revenge scenario. Toren just didn't like her.

And then he had felt it. It wasn't something snapping, and it wasn't as if anything had been cut. Rather...it felt as though something had reached into the center of Toren's being and yanked a part out.

The mana connection between him and Erin had vanished. It had vanished, and Toren realized in those next moments of panic and confusion that he was dying.

Because his supply of mana was gone, and Toren was running out. He had already run low on mana from fighting in Esthelm; now it seemed to be leaving his body faster with each passing second.

He had known he was going to die. And so Toren had reached out, feeling the spell in his body burning his life force away. He had searched for something, anything that could give him a few more seconds and found it.

Mana. Magic. In the bodies of the zombies and ghouls following him. So Toren had reached out and...taken it from them.

At the time he hadn't understood it. Now, sitting in the darkness of Liscor's dungeon, Toren did. He had stolen the mana from the undead. They had it. It was what gave them the ability to move, to function. Without it they would become dead bodies, or bones. Like Toren.

But he had needed mana, so Toren had reached out and taken it. It shouldn't have been that easy, but these were the dead Toren controlled with his [Command Lesser Undead] Skill, and so in some way they were his. So he had taken their magic and felt it fill him. Not enough, but with more than he had had.

So he could steal magic. At least, from things he owned. That was a revelation to Toren, although again, he hadn't been in a position to understand that at the time. Now the skeleton thought about this new ability distantly, without real interest.

He was like...a thing that sucked stuff...from things. Toren didn't have an appropriate word in his head. A straw? That was it! A straw. He was like a Straw Skeleton, something that could feed on the mana of other things. Or maybe a sponge. A Sponge Skeleton.

Names didn't matter. It was the learning that had saved Toren. He had taken the life of the undead, watched them fall to the ground, lifeless corpses once more. He had lived. But he had still been running out of mana.

So he had searched for more. Suddenly bereft of the thing that had kept him alive, Toren was now focused on it. As someone who had no oxygen would be focused on breathing. And there was magic all around him! It was in the earth, the air, the grass—

But far too little of it. Maybe a zombie could have existed on that ambient mana, but Toren was like a raging bonfire to their modest torches. Something in him was burning through magic at an incredible rate. Erin hadn't provided Toren with as much mana as someone like Ceria or Pisces could have, but it had still been enough to sustain him.

Searching, Toren had felt something deep in the earth. Something strong. A source of power. He had searched for a way to get to that spot, and remembered the dungeon. He remembered where he had fallen in and desperately made his way to that spot.

There he had met the small, white Gnoll that used to live at the inn. Mrsha? Mrsha. She had taken one look at Toren and fled. She had gone right to the very crevasse Toren was headed to, and actually tumbled in by herself!

She was clumsy. And she'd let go when Toren went to pull her out. He hadn't been sure if he was going to stab her or let her go in any event; he just needed her out of the way so he could get into the dungeon. But she had fallen, and that was that.

It was Toren's descent that mattered. He had carefully climbed down a few feet into the dungeon down the sheer drop, lost his grip, and tumbled to the bottom. He hadn't broken—but he had fractured several bones.

But then he had been in the dungeon. And oh, blessedly, there had been *magic*.

It filled the dark hallways of the dungeon. It practically radiated from some rooms, and Toren knew the ambient energy could fuel any number of undead, or other monsters. It was enough to actually fill him with magical energy, enough so that he could reassemble himself a few times if he needed to.

That was a relief. But Toren hadn't done any fighting then. Suddenly free of the need to survive, the skeleton had seen the small Gnoll running away into the darkness, and heard her howling. He had seen the adventurers and the big Drake kill a score of monsters with commendable skill and bravery. He had seen them climb out of the pit.

And he hadn't felt a thing. Toren had sat down as the battle had raged, as killing—his favorite thing to do—had been occurring in spades. He had

sat and been still. Because now Toren had realized the truth. The awful truth, which held him in place. That wouldn't go away.

Erin Solstice was dead.

And it was his fault.

The link between Toren and Erin was gone. She was no longer providing him with mana. There could only be one reason for that, Toren knew.

She was gone. He had gotten her killed.

And he hadn't *meant* it.

Okay, *okay*. He had deliberately pulled Erin countless miles away from her inn and left her deliberately near a cave with a sleeping bear in it. And maybe Toren had thrown some rocks at a pack of wolves as he'd walked off. But that had just been a playful attempt at murder, a casual homicide attempt! He hadn't...hadn't ever thought it would happen.

It was strange. Toren stirred. He lay down on his left side, turning his head to stare at the rest of his body. He had tried to get Erin killed back then, full of anger for being forced to pull her about, and those stupid *bells*, but he hadn't thought she'd really get killed by the bear, deep down.

And that was strange. Toren was dead. He could tell when he was having odd thoughts. Why wouldn't he have expected Erin to die? Everyone died. Even the undead.

Toren understood death, now. He knew it intimately. And killing. He liked it. Toren had learned to kill animals, monsters, and people. It was all the same. All you had to do was stab things, preferably with something sharp, like a sword. Toren was good at it. He was a front-stabber, a backstabber, a side-stabber, and when he could get away with it, an eye-stabber.

Anything could die. Toren was sure he could kill anything with a sharp enough sword. But Erin? How could *she* die? She was...Erin. The person who'd given him purpose, the second (and more important) person he'd ever seen. His Master. Or Mistress. He hadn't meant for her to die.

Toren paused.

Okay, he *had* meant for her to die. But part of him didn't really expect it to happen. It just seemed impossible to Toren. Still seemed impossible, really.

He remembered Erin fighting Skinner, fighting off hundreds of undead, *singing*...and her games of chess with the Antinium. She was...had been... at the center of the world Toren knew. He could imagine killing anyone, imagine anyone's dead body, but hers.

He couldn't believe she would just die like that. But she had. And it was his fault. Because he had left her. And it was his duty to protect her.

He had abandoned that duty. Left it behind. And only now did Toren regret. Erin was dead. Dead and never coming back.

It was the first time he had ever thought of death as a bad thing. Dead things didn't bother Toren. *He* was dead. So what if things never moved? It hadn't mattered. But Erin—she wouldn't move. Ever. She was dead. She would rot. She would never speak.

She was dead.

Forever.

There was nowhere to hide in his mind. Toren couldn't lie to himself. He was dead, and there were no comforting illusions anymore. Only the painful reality.

She was dead.

And it was his fault.

After a while—after a bit of dust had gathered on his body, Toren moved. He stood up. Not because he felt better; Toren never forgot. Memory never faded for him; it was as fresh as the moment he had experienced things. But he felt like he had to do something. Sitting was not working.

Toren leaned against a wall, like he'd seen Erin do when she was upset. It didn't make him feel better. Maybe it was the wrong wall?

He tried the same thing on the opposite wall. No luck. Toren thumped his skull against the stones. That didn't help either. He looked around for

his sword and remembered he'd dropped it, and everything else, in his haste to get here.

So. He was weaponless, trapped in a dungeon full of horrible monsters, and Erin was dead. Toren stared at a wall. Aside from that last bit, things were fine.

Nothing was fine. Nothing would ever be fine. For a second, Toren debated walking out into the corridor and finding a monster to destroy his body a few times. Or maybe he should climb out of the dungeon and lie in the snow until he finally ran out of mana.

To Toren, the notion of oblivion held its own certain charm. But there was a part of him that was afraid of the blank look in the eyes of the dead. After all, they had a second chance, to come back as undead like Toren. But if *he* died, what then?

If Erin became a zombie, or a Ghoul, would there be anything of her in there? Toren paused. He didn't want to see a dead Erin. And he didn't want to die. There was a strong part of him that shouted that.

Yes. Death wasn't an option for Toren. Despite it all, he wanted to live. And so Toren did. He dusted himself off, looked around, and began to think.

He was alive. Good. That was a good start. Now...what? He was in a dungeon, because he was on his own now. Because he had no mana—

No, scratch that. Because he *used* too much mana! In theory, he could live like an ordinary skeleton out on the surface. But it was rapidly becoming more apparent that Toren was no ordinary skeleton.

Obviously, because he could level. And think. And he had a name. But there was something else.

Toren felt at his body. His skeletal fingers encountered only yellow-white bone. Was there something off about him?

He carefully pulled a rib out and studied it. Nope. Just a normal rib. His rib. Toren threw it over his shoulder and waited.

After a second or two, the rib rose off the ground and flew back towards his body. It snapped back into place. Toren stared at his reattached rib.

Now *that*. That wasn't normal. No other skeleton Toren had met—undead or otherwise—did that. But why did it happen?

Toren thought for a second, and then cast around. He didn't look with any visual senses, but rather, with that strange ability he'd used out of desperation not long ago. He reached out and searched for the magic with his mind.

There. Toren regarded himself in his head. He could...sense the magic in him. There was a good bit of it, but it wasn't uniform. There was a flow to it. It occupied his bones. In fact, his bones were the place where the mana was stored. Toren could see how it ran through the bones, absorbed by the spell that animated him from the dungeon. But there were also points where it concentrated, where his body used more mana.

Specific bones, in fact. Toren counted four of them.

Bone one? Second-lowest left rib. Bone two was his right shinbone. The tibia, not the fibula. Bone three was his clavicle. The left one. And the last bone...fourth rib from the top on the right side.

Why were they different? To Toren's fingers, they were no different from—wait a second. He felt suspiciously at the ends of the rib. The two 'special' ones were slightly shorter than the others! And here—his tibia was shorter than the one on his right side! He was unbalanced!

That indignation lasted only a second. Toren plucked at the bones, removing the ribs to look at them. Why were *these* bones different? Why did they use more mana, and why didn't they match the rest of his body? Toren could only assume it was because he wasn't one skeleton.

He was multiple skeletons.

The [Skeleton Knight] thought about this. Then he fainted.

It wasn't really fainting, honestly. Toren just swooned over and lay on the ground, like he'd seen Lyonette do once or twice when he'd dropped a

bunch of Corusdeer intestines on her head. He got up after a while, but the shock was still there, making his hands tremble.

He was multiple skeletons. Toren felt betrayed by the knowledge. Why hadn't anyone *told* him?

Then again...it made sense. Toren was far too intelligent and powerful to be a single skeleton. He nodded to himself, satisfied with that explanation. Then he frowned, or rather, thought about frowning.

He had the ability to sense mana. Not just ambient mana, but to look at something and tell where the mana was concentrated. It was useful, but also a mystery. Because Toren had never learned the [Mana Sense] Skill, if that even *was* a Skill. So that meant...Toren took several minutes to figure this one out. When he had it he slapped his head off his body in surprise.

You could have a skill which was not a Skill.

It was a mind-blowing revelation. And it immediately made Toren question everything he thought he had known. If you could be good at something without a Skill—like sword fighting, why not learn as much as you could instead of trying to level up and gain Skills?

Maybe...maybe because other people weren't as good at learning as Toren? He was great at learning. He'd learned that you couldn't bring dead fish into the inn (unless they were carefully dried off and not in pieces), how to light fires, how to carry plates without breaking them, how to bother Erin so she'd let him go outside...

But it occurred to Toren that there were things he could do that he didn't *know* he could do. His mana sensing abilities, for one. That was odd. Could all skeletons do that? Could all living people?

No. Surely not. But if Toren could do that, what else could he make his body do?

He wasn't sure. It was another thing to explore, but right now Toren was more concerned with survival. Because he would survive. He would live. He didn't know how to die. He must have forgotten how.

Plus, it stood to reason that Toren was better at living than at dying. He lived all the time, and he'd only died once (as far as he knew). He must not have been very good at it, to have only died once.

So live. And part of living was exploring, finding his whereabouts. Toren looked around.

It was dark. That didn't bother Toren. But in the darkness, there wasn't much to see. The corridor was long, wide, tall, and filled with other unhelpful adjectives. Toren had been here before and knew the corridor just led to other intersections and passageways of the same.

This place was a labyrinth. And unfortunately or fortunately depending on how you looked at it, it was filled with monsters. Toren had seen them the first time he'd fallen down here and run away from an enchanted suit of armor.

He'd run around, found a huge staircase going up, run through several rooms, one filled with fire, another with some kind of spell trap he'd dashed through, and then found himself in a room with a bunch of statues and a hole in the wall. He'd dashed out of that and met a bunch of Goblins, who'd been very helpful and helped him kill that blasted suit of armor out on the surface.

So in short, Toren had no idea where he was. He only knew there were trapped rooms 'above', a labyrinth 'here' filled with monsters, and presumably a lot more dungeon he hadn't explored. But there was a way out.

For now, Toren dismissed the idea of trying to find a way out of the dungeon. That, ironically, was the most dangerous option for him, lacking a mana source as he was. To go above he'd need a mana potion, or a way of generating more magic to survive off of. So he'd have to stay here.

With the monsters.

Toren patted his side and remembered he'd left his sword somewhere. He looked for it.

There. Toren picked up a somewhat dulled longsword and inspected it critically. It was iron, the crossguard cracked, and covered with dried blood on a few spots. Not ideal for cutting, but it would do.

Sword? Check. Toren needed armor, a shield, and maybe a safe place to run to if he found trouble. He went searching.

The first thing Toren found was a bloodstain. It was yellow. He stared at it, and then noticed the burst sack of flesh next to it. It looked squished. Toren inspected the remains for anything interesting.

Nope. Something had been killed, and by a particularly heavy blow. That was all.

The skeleton went on. The next thing he found was the killer. It was a huge, bear-like creature, all fur and claws, but it had been holding a maul. It was dead. It had one of its hands grasping a short stinger in its side; practically a scratch. But Toren stared at the creature's bared teeth and twisted expression of pain and knew it had died from poison.

Odd. The bear-thing sort of resembled a Gnoll. Toren propped it up against a wall so he could investigate it better. It was fur-chested, and had no garments except for a loincloth which hid...Toren peeled it away...more of the beast. That was disappointing. Toren had always wondered what clothing hid, but it just turned out to be more of the same. He poked dismissively at a dangling bit of the creature and then inspected its face.

There were definitely Gnoll characteristics here, but this creature had a far broader back, and Gnolls were already pretty big. The teeth were bigger, the head was squatter and actually seemed a bit smaller, and this not-Gnoll had claws that were long and dangerous, not like a Gnoll's paws at all.

Was it some kind of relative of the Gnolls? Toren shook his head. He eyed the maul and decided it wasn't for him either. Too heavy.

It was a shame to just leave the dead not-Gnoll here, though. Toren thought it would have made an excellent zombie; practically impossible to kill. But he couldn't raise the dead, just command them. So he left it there and went on.

Down the corridor, past glowing runes on the walls. Toren stared at a couple of them as they lit up, sensing his presence. He didn't think much of them until he passed by a cluster of them. They turned bright green, flared up, and an explosion blew the skeleton to bits.

In the time it took for Toren to reassemble, he concluded that the labyrinth was probably full of such traps. He could sense the magic clustering around them. Toren got up, dropped his sword, went back for the maul next to the dead not-Gnoll and ran back. He began furiously smashing

the heavy weapon into the runes on the wall, but didn't make a dent, even when the maul's head snapped off the sturdy wooden shaft.

Okay, the runes were there to stay. Toren just had to *avoid* them. He could do that. He stomped past the runes, skirting them by sticking to the other side of the corridor. He made it ten more steps, and then fell into a pit trap.

That *hadn't* been his fault! True, after he'd angrily hauled himself out Toren could see the upraised plate of stone that had opened the ground soon after to send him falling into a short pit full of sharp, stone spikes and bones. But how was he supposed to know it had been there?

Toren walked off, looking closely at the ground and walls and ceiling. He spotted five more traps down this corridor, avoided them all, and then noticed the dead spider at the end of the corridor. It was quite dead; something had burnt it to a crisp. Quite recently too, because it was still a bit hot.

Another monster. Well, well. Toren found he was at a T-intersection and headed left. He frowned as he noticed bits of shell, or some other black fragments on the ground. Then he noticed the webbing and slowed down. When he got to the open doorway at the end, Toren cautiously poked his head through the entryway and looked up.

Oh my. That was the skeleton's thought. Toren's gaze showed him a huge circular column room, far longer vertically than it was horizontally. And stretching the entire height of the room, sitting in webs, tending to huge cocoons of their young hanging from the walls, the ceiling, bunched together like grapes, were skittering shadows, creeping shapes.

Shield Spiders.

Toren eyed them. None of the spiders had picked up he was here, so he carefully tiptoed backwards. He wasn't afraid of spiders, but some of them were *big*. Was that how big Shield Spiders got? A few of the ones near the top were bigger than *Rock Crabs*.

The [Tactician] in Toren's head told him that going into that room and fighting like he normally did was sheer suicide. The rest of Toren agreed. But looking wouldn't hurt. He poked his head back around and saw something that made him go suddenly still.

Pawn. Toren's keen not-eyes picked out a silent shape, struggling, being hauled by several Shield Spiders into the room from another entrance. It was Pawn! Toren watched with interest as the Antinium was dragged towards a cocoon. It ruptured, and countless tiny spiders swarmed out. They covered the Antinium as Pawn fought, but there were too many and he was covered in webs. In moments, the frantic thrashing slowed. The Shield Spiderlings continued to gnaw at their prey. Pawn was dead.

Toren wondered what Erin would have thought of that. He felt bad for Pawn. But Pawn was dead. And oh, look! Toren spotted another Pawn being dragged into the room. This Pawn was already dead.

Two Pawns? Wait a second. Toren's eyes would have narrowed had he skin. There weren't *two* Pawns. And then he saw more Antinium being dragged in, and more partially eaten, hung in the webbing.

Hold on a moment. More Antinium? Toren thought about that and concluded maybe these weren't Pawn. They could have just been...the others that sometimes came to Erin's inn. But they didn't have names, so Toren didn't remember them. He stared at all the other not-Pawns and shrugged. What were Antinium doing down here anyways? Didn't they know it was dangerous?

Toren turned away from the nest of Shield Spiders and noticed something else interesting. Caught in the detritus around the spiders' lair, some other remnants of their victims had fallen. Toren saw a stinger, like the one he'd seen earlier, a crimson pincher, devoid of a body, a rotted arm that seemed far too thin and small to have belonged to a Human, and a head. It stared at Toren and he stared back. Well, there were apparently giant centipedes down here as well.

There were so many monsters about! Okay, perhaps they weren't popping out every two feet, but the dungeon's population was clearly actively growing and being cut back down to size as monsters fought with each other and guarded their lairs.

Toren poked his head around the corner again, and eyed the bulging cavern of Shield Spiders and the obscenely glistening eggs hanging from every web. He thought for a second about cause and effect, about actions and consequences, about the nature of causality in general. Then he got bored, threw a stone at the nearest cluster of eggs and ran for it.

Around two dozen angry Shield Spiders chased Toren down the corridor as he sprinted past all the traps he'd found. He stopped at the intersection and looked back. None of the Shield Spiders had made it to him. They'd all died at the first trap, which Toren had run right past since he could see the magical runes hidden in the grime.

The Shield Spiders, or what was left of them, were sprawled around the trap, mostly in pieces. Toren stared at the runes. They weren't glowing now, but he was curious as to how it had killed the Shield Spiders.

Toren paused, looked about, and went back to find more Shield Spiders. When he eventually managed to lure a few towards the trap, Toren was treated to a horrific sight.

The Shield Spiders went *pop* as they crossed over the trapped bit of floor. There was no waiting about, no warning. They just exploded from the insides, as if something had blown a huge bubble of air right into their bellies and made them burst.

It was so entertaining that Toren made eight more spiders activate the trap, until the magic stopped working and he had to stomp the last spider to death with his foot. But though the energy of the spell had been exhausted, Toren could sense the latent magic in the dungeon slowly working to replenish it.

So, the traps were here to stay. The monsters either learned to avoid them, or died. And they tended to thrive, if only on a diet of Antinium and each other. Toren nodded to himself as he walked away from the corridor, making a mental note to come back and have fun exploding spiders at a later date. He took another left, then a right, flattened himself against a wall when he heard a sound, and then saw the corridor turn into stairs.

Not the same stairs that led up to the rooms with traps. The purple flames in Toren's eye sockets narrowed to a pinpoint as he stared up the short staircase. What was this now? He could see more runes on an overhang where the wall went down to block off the corridor, leaving only a metal door in its place. They glowed above the simple door. Not a spell, but words. A message, etched in stone and enchanted to last forever.

Toren eyed the letters. They were all interconnected. It was a flowing, elegant script. And what was most curious to Toren—they weren't the

words Erin or any of the people around Liscor used. This language was different entirely.

It was a curious thing that everyone mostly spoke the same language to Toren, yet they wrote differently. But Toren could read dead languages and living ones with ease. They were just meaning, and his undead mind could translate any meaning.

Not that these words necessarily mattered. These said the usual things Toren was used to reading. He read things all the time in Erin's inn. They were all the same.

Special on Fish! 2 sp. for all you can eat!

No taking dishes! That means you, Relc!

Horrible death awaits all those who enter this place. Your bodies shall be taken and made part of the Mother of Graves.

It was all the same, really. Toren dismissively walked past the etched warnings on the wall and went up the steps. He opened the door and disappeared through. Ten seconds later he walked quickly back out of the door, shut it, and decided to go somewhere else at speed. Things burst through the doorway, chasing him, but they didn't follow him far.

And then Toren found the dead adventurer.

She wasn't any more special than the last ones Toren had met, or so he felt on first glance. There were dead adventurers, dead monsters, dead animals—a few birds, of all things, probably lost from above. But there was something this adventurer had that the other bodies Toren had come across did not.

A cloak.

It was wrapped around her. The adventurer's flesh was rotted, although Toren could still see her bared teeth, snarling in defiance. She had an open hand, fingers twisted and broken. She had probably been holding a sword,

but whomever—or whatever—had killed her had taken it, ripping it out of her death grip to do so.

Toren could also tell she was dead because most adventurers had a throat. Hers was missing.

The other dead people lying around her looked like they'd also gone down fighting. There were twelve bodies in all, fairly well preserved. Toren wasn't sure if they were freshly dead, really dead, or just old. As a skeleton, he didn't particularly care about the effects of decomposition, since everyone eventually ended up looking like him.

But the cloak. It was wrapped around the adventuress. Toren gingerly bent and tugged it away from the dead woman. He had to undo the clasp at the neck, but then it was in his hands. He held it in front of him, appraising it.

It was...well, it was a ragged brown cloak, a bit holey, and certainly nothing to write home about. If Toren had a home. And if Erin was alive to write to. But it spoke to him.

There was something in the skeleton's mind that told him the cloak was important. It wasn't the [Tactician] bit of him, or the warrior, or the bit that said that he could wash the cloak so Erin wouldn't complain that it smelled—no, this was something else. A new part of Toren, coming to life, speaking to the rest of him.

It was a vague sense of *style*. And Toren felt the cloak had style in spades, especially around his shoulders.

Carefully, he threw the cloak around him and put it on. The skeleton looked at himself. He couldn't see the general impression he made with the cloak on, but he felt it looked good.

Clothing. Fashion. Style. These weren't words that had ever interested Toren, but the cloak had awoken something in him. Erin had always been fussing about clothes, whether they were ripped, dirty, on or—she had a big problem with Toren staring at her without clothing.

Maybe this was more important than Toren had thought? The skeleton pondered this as he looked for something to admire himself with. After all,

clothing wasn't like armor. It could barely stop a bad sneeze, let alone a sword thrust. So maybe the value of clothes was simply in...looking good.

Aha! Toren found what he wanted in the dead adventuress' pack. He pulled out a broken fragment that shone in the darkness. A piece of a mirror, perhaps. Yes, Toren rifled around in the dead adventuress' pack and found the other fragments, all smashed. He carefully reassembled them on the ground and studied himself.

A skeleton wearing a cloak stared up at Toren. He looked at it in shock. It was a skeleton. With a cloak. That was it.

Not that cool at all.

Toren drooped. He'd really thought the cloak would look amazing on him, but it didn't. It just sort of sagged on his body. It didn't blow in the wind! Mainly because there was no wind in the dungeon.

He tore the cloak off and hurled it on the ground. For good measure, Toren stamped on it. He didn't look good. Erin looked good in some clothing. Toren distinctly remembered how she'd looked after the battle with Skinner, her shirt and pants torn, covered in blood and grime and guts. That was a *look*. Toren could admire that, and that annoying [Knight] he'd fought in Esthelm. If he, Toren, were fighting an opponent that shiny, he'd feel a bit impressed.

They had style. Toren did not. He kicked at the cloak, stared at it, and then picked it back up and lovingly stroked it. It was a good cloak. It spoke to him. Yes, it wasn't the cloak's fault; it was Toren's! He just wasn't wearing *enough* to make the cloak look good.

Toren looked around. There was a group of dead adventurers here. They all had clothes. Toren bent down and began claiming it. He didn't know why he was doing it. It was just a thought.

Erin had worn clothing. So Toren would too. Just to see what it was like. Because anything that reminded Toren of Erin hurt—but it hurt more when he tried to forget.

So Toren dressed himself for the first time since he'd been created. It was hard. Not because he didn't have a surplus of garments to wear, but because it was so hard getting it *off* the dead bodies without ripping

anything! Toren had never learned what buttons or belts or clips were. He ruined a good deal of pants before he realized they were attached to the waist and that pulling too hard would just pull the pants and the legs straight off the corpse.

But he did have clothing. Toren claimed most of it from the dead adventuress, for the sheer reason that if she was fashionable enough to use a cloak, she probably had good taste. She had been wearing leather armor, pierced in some places, over her clothes. Toren ignored that at first, and began slipping on her clothes.

They hung on him. Toren stared at himself in the mirror and picked disconsolately at the very loose, very ill-fitting clothes. The adventuress hadn't been that big, but she had skin. Toren didn't.

But still, he persisted. Toren grabbed the shirt off of someone else and tore it up to pad out his body so the shirt would fit. He began assembling the garments, putting them on. Tattered cloak, pants, shirt...Toren had to put the stiff leather armor *underneath* the clothes to pad out the clothing on his thin frame. That made him sufficiently bulky.

Actually, Toren considered himself normal and everyone else obscenely fat and heavy. The depths of anorexia wouldn't come close to Toren's frame. At least, not until the end.

Now looking somewhat decently Human-shaped, Toren attempted to figure out where the rest of the clothing on the dead adventurer went. He'd seen Erin use a bra—and seen her naked for that matter, much to her displeasure—but he couldn't see the point on his body.

Still, there wasn't much point to clothes to begin with, so why quibble? Toren stuffed some rags into the bra and patted them to make everything look right. Then he realized he needed something for his head. Because if he was going to look like a Human, like Erin, he had to get rid of the grinning skull that stared back at him in the mirror as well. Toren thought about how to do this.

Hats were no good. He had a hood on the cloak, but from the front Toren's features would be fairly obvious. Toren thought about this and eyed the dead adventuress' face. He *could* cut it off, but faces probably weren't

that easy to fake. Plus, it was already rotting, which didn't bother Toren, but the flies did.

A...mask. Yes, that was the thing. Toren looked for a mask, but none of the adventurers had one. Slightly put out, he wondered where he might make something to hide his face and had a brilliant idea.

The dead Shield Spiders had lovely carapaces. True, many of them were in pieces from the trap, but the wonderful thing about spiders was that they had webbing. A bit of work and Toren came up with a mask that covered his entire face. He gingerly stuck it to the front of his skull with some web and trooped back to the mirror to inspect his new look.

The skeleton held his breath as the skeleton on the ground stepped into vision. Only, in the mirror, there was no skeleton at all.

A slim, female figure stared up at Toren. She was female because she had bulges in the right place, and because she had some curves that Toren had worked really hard to get right. She was wearing dirty clothing, ragged and tattered, wrapped and held in place with cloth fragments. The look actually wasn't that bad and the bindings added to the 'warrior' look in Toren's head.

But what really drew the mysterious figure together were the mask and the cloak. The dark brown cloak swirled around the female warrior as she lifted one gloved hand to adjust the mask on her face. The mask was dark black, the surface shiny and rough. It covered her face, leaving only two narrow slits for eyes—

Toren's admiration halted as he realized the eyes on the figure in the mirror were glowing. Dismayed, he bent and saw two purple flames flickering in the eyeholes of his mask. Toren cursed. Those gave him away! He thought hard. Could he get away with closing the gaps in the mask off? No, but then he wouldn't be able to see. What about making the flames dimmer? Could he do that?

In the mirror, Toren saw the flames in the figure's eyes slowly dim. They grew smaller and smaller and then, quite suddenly, went out.

Toren jerked back. He felt at his eyes, looked around. He could still see! But when he looked in the mirror, only dark slits on the mask were visible. You couldn't tell who was looking out. Anyone could have been

underneath. A Human, or a Drake—no, Drakes had tails. Or a Gnoll—but Gnolls were bigger...

Okay, there could be *any* kind of Human underneath. Or a half-Elf! The figure straightened up. She admired her ragged look, her masked face, her thin but not undead-thin frame. She struck a pose and felt the innards of her ‘body’ shift, held in place by sticky Shield Spider webbing and the clothing she wore.

And she smiled. She traced a finger over her mask in a smile.

Toren grinned. She had *style*.

An hour later, Toren had to concede that style had its disadvantages. When she’d gotten bored of running about the dungeon, posing and admiring herself in the mirror, she’d begun testing out the limits of her new form.

Because it *was* a new body, or as good as one. Toren felt as though this new shape was person unto itself. Herself. This new Toren was more Erin-like, more Human. She had more weaknesses like this, but Toren felt as though she understood more of Erin this way.

And one of the things she understood was how *annoying* clothes were. Toren had the opportunity to skirmish with a few creatures in the time after she’d dressed. The first opponents she’d found were some rather unpleasantly large maggots, as high as Toren’s midriff and wider than she was, coming to feast on the bodies.

Toren had killed them, if only because she felt she owed the dead group of adventurers that. But it had been considerably harder than she’d expected. She’d tried to roll and dive as the maggots leapt blindly at her, trying to bring her down, and found she was slower, less nimble.

Fighting with clothes on made Toren feel like she was moving in slow-motion. She couldn’t roll and dive out of the way, and she wasn’t able to bend at crazy angles to slash her foes like normal. She still killed the

maggots of course; they were slow blobs and once you punctured their admittedly thick hides they spewed their guts.

But that led to the second problem, which was that Toren's wonderful clothes were now dirty! She brushed at the slime covering her arms, quite upset about the sudden change in her appearance. So *this* was why Erin kept telling him not to bring dirty things into her inn! She could only imagine how hard she'd have to scrub to get the stains out.

But Toren was happy, in a way she couldn't describe. She ran through the dungeon, happily hacking at things, running away, and in general enjoying herself. This was something new, something exciting! It was a challenge to fight without damaging her clothes, and it was amusing to think that no one had any clue that there was a skeleton stabbing them to death, rather than a regular living being.

Only, there was no one to share that knowledge with! Until Toren met the group of adventurers, that was.

It was some time after Toren had dressed herself. She couldn't have said when, only that she'd acquired a good splattering of blood on top of her clothes, and leveled up. Time was hard to tell in the dungeon. But as Toren was walking down the halls, reflecting that she would need a new blade soon—hers was quite dull from use—she heard a sound.

Immediately she stiffened and got ready to fight. Or run. It was impossible to play dead, dressed as she was. But these sounds weren't the noises a monster would make. Toren turned her head in disbelief as she heard *voices*.

“—Freezing my beard off here, Insill! Why in the name of forge fire are we down here without backup?”

“You don't have a beard, Dasha. And the magical food that [Innkeeper] fed us only lets us use one enchantment at a time, remember?”

“Huh. *She* didn't know that.”

“But she gave us back our coin, and we're set for the next eight hours. Deal with the cold. Only a few groups know about her magical cooking, and so we have a chance.”

Toren listened with fascination to the two voices arguing. People? Down here? Then a growling voice, soft and commanding, interrupted.

“A single enchantment won’t do us any good if we’re attacked by something truly dangerous. We should be quiet. We are scouting. Information about this new part of the dungeon is worth its weight in gold, but only if we get back alive.”

The voices cut off at once. Toren paused. They were just up ahead. She had a rough map of this part of the dungeon in her head, and she knew they were right next to the hole she’d fallen through. Had these adventurers come down the same way? And if they had, what was Toren going to do about them?

Part of Toren knew exactly what to do. Kill them. That was what he’d always done. Kill anything that moved, because he might level! But she wavered. She wondered—

And then soft yellow light flooded the hallway. It stunned Toren, because she’d been in the darkness so long she’d forgotten what light was *like*. It illuminated the dark corridor, threw her form into relief. She spotted the group of five adventurers at the same time they saw her.

They were five. Two were clearly warriors; a short woman with an axe in front wearing armor, standing next to a young woman with a curved sword. A Gnoll and a hooded figure were looking over their shoulders as they walked behind the warriors, guarding the rear. The Gnoll held a shortbow, and the hooded figure held something thick and flat in one furred hand. They were all following a Drake with black scales, who was dressed in leather armor. He had a dagger out. They all froze when they saw Toren.

“Watch out!”

The Gnoll snapped the words first. He lifted the bow up, but the hooded [Mage] grabbed his arm.

“Don’t shoot! It’s an adventurer!”

Toren had been charging forwards, ready to cut into the group and slay the [Mage] with her Skill before escaping. But she halted when she heard those words.

An adventurer. They thought *she* was like them! For a second, Toren's head was filled with clouds, and she felt bliss permeate every inch of her being.

They thought she looked like one of them. Her clothing had worked! For that reason alone, Toren didn't immediately try to kill them all.

Still, there was tension in the air as the adventurers backed away from Toren. The Gnoll thrust the [Mage]'s hand away and nocked his bow. He didn't aim *at* Toren, but the threat was there. The two warriors conferred with the Drake with the dagger and he called out cautiously towards Toren.

"Hallo? We're friendly! Are you an adventurer? Are you lost? Look—we're not threats!"

He sheathed the dagger at his waist, and the other adventurers lowered their weapons. After a moment's hesitation, Toren lowered her sword. She wanted to see what would happen if she did.

"Great! Uh—are you okay?"

Now this...was a problem. Toren hesitated, because she couldn't speak. When he'd been running around and Erin had been alive, he'd often wished he could open his mouth and say something. But unlike the spell that had given him vision, it hadn't seen fit to give him intangible vocal cords as well. And now *she* was facing a situation where not speaking might get tricky.

Toren improvised. She raised her hand hesitantly and waved it back and forth. The adventurers watched her carefully, and she saw them turn to whisper to each other. The black-scaled Drake who seemed to be acting as their spokesperson called out.

"Are you...mute? Can you talk?"

Toren nodded to the first question and then shook her head. The Drake turned to his companions. He whispered, but Toren didn't have ears and so his magical hearing far eclipsed that of anyone but a Gnoll's.

"I think it might be safe. Come on, let's go over!"

"You go up. I will stay back with Anith. Best just in case, no?"

The Gnoll whispered back. The Drake nodded and he and the two females walked forwards to meet Toren. She stared at the three of them. They stared back.

“Dead gods, is that a mask?”

The shorter woman, who had arms like a [Blacksmith] exclaimed the instant she got close to Toren. She was holding a metal lantern up and she shone it at Toren’s face. The skeleton held her breath. This was the moment of truth.

“Stop that! You’re blinding her!”

The young woman swatted the lantern down. She was Human, and holding a curved blade Toren couldn’t help but admire. He had never seen a katana before, so unlike Erin, he couldn’t make the mistake of assuming it was one. The sword the woman held was no katana—it was too wide, and the tip was double-edged. It was a long blade, and the young woman held it casually at her side as she spoke to the short woman with the axe. But she was watching Toren warily out of the corner of her eye as she spoke.

The Drake was the next person to speak. Toren looked down at him. He was thinner and shorter than any other male Drake she’d seen, but friendly enough. He grinned up at her, looking slightly nervous.

“Sorry about that. It’s just that we didn’t expect to find *anyone* down here. What are you doing alone?”

Toren had no good answer, so she shrugged. She was quite entertained by the notion that they thought she was like them, and wondered if she should disabuse them by stabbing them in the face. But she thought it would be more entertaining to see how long she could keep up the ruse.

“You can’t speak, right! Sorry. Uh—what should I say?”

The Drake turned to the two warriors. The young woman with the curved sword frowned.

“Are you hurt?”

Toren shook her head.

“Are you lost?”

Again, a shake of the head. The adventuress paused.

“So you’re a solo adventurer, exploring *alone*?”

Toren hesitated, and then nodded her head. The Drake’s jaw fell open.

“No way. You mean you’re down here—but we thought—how long have you been here?”

The skeleton masquerading as an adventurer shrugged. She was really enjoying this. She held up her sword to show them the bloodstains, and the short woman exclaimed when she lifted her lantern to see.

“Burn my beard, that’s one battered sword! What have you been doing, smashing rocks with it? That thing deserves to be melted down for scrap, not used as a weapon!”

Toren glared at the short woman as the young woman with the curved blade rolled her eyes. She rounded on her companion, sounding irate.

“For the last time, you don’t *have* a beard, Dasha! Why do you keep saying that?”

“It’s what my people say! Don’t judge me, long legs!”

“You’re only *part*-Dwarf! And I’m only a head and a half taller than you are!”

“I was raised by Dwarves, not Humans, alright?”

The two began to argue, completely forgetting Toren was there. She scratched at the back of her hooded head. The Drake sidled closer to her.

“Sorry about that. We’re uh, a newer team. *That’s* your weapon?”

Toren nodded again. She could understand the part-Dwarf warrior’s point. She didn’t like having the sword either. She wondered if she could take the one the young woman had...

“Insill!”

A voice rang out from behind the Drake, cutting the argument between the two female adventurers short. Insill turned and waved.

“Come on over! I think there’s no danger!”

He turned sheepishly to Toren.

“Sorry about that. You know how it is with dungeons.”

Toren nodded understandingly. They were being quite smart. The foolish thing was *trusting* her. She eyed the other two adventurers as they came over. One was a Gnoll and the other—

There were five adventurers. Two Humans, a Drake, a Gnoll and a... Toren squinted at the fifth member of the group. The last person was just weird. He had fur and looked sort of like a Gnoll, but very not at the same time. Where Gnolls had a distinct, thickset build and a certain scruffiness to their fur, this person was different. His fur was black, sleek, and he had a more elongated head, closer to a dog than the mixed appearance of a Gnoll.

If Toren had known about cultures from Erin's world, she would have said the fifth person looked like one of the Egyptian gods, like Anubis, perhaps. He was slightly taller and thinner than the average Human male, and he was carrying a book which glowed faintly in one of his paws.

"Who is this, Insill?"

"I think she's a solo adventurer, Anith."

"In a new dungeon?"

Shock ran through the [Mage]'s voice. The other adventurers looked at Toren, who silently preened in their stares. At last, the Gnoll spoke.

"Well, we shall not bother you, yes? We are exploring this dungeon as you are, Miss Adventurer. Unless there is something you wish to warn us of?"

Toren thought about all the horrible ways to die she'd discovered and thought about how much she cared for this group's wellbeing. She shook her head lightly.

"In that case, we shall be on our way."

The Gnoll nodded, but the Drake stopped him.

"Hold on Larr! We should ask if we can team up!"

"Team up?"

The others stared at Insill in surprise, but the Drake nodded.

"She clearly knows the area if she's been down here. And there's safety in numbers. What about a team up? We'll split the loot evenly amongst us

all.”

The idea threw Toren far more than the other adventurers. Her? Team up with them? For what purpose? But then the idea tickled her. Why not? She felt good after being taken for an adventurer, and she could always betray them after they killed some things. She nodded, the adventurers conferred, their leader, the [Mage], agreed and so it was done.

A few minutes later, Toren found the group introducing themselves to her, which was another unique experience. Erin had *never* introduced anyone to Toren. But now the black-scaled Drake, Insill, was doing so for Toren.

“This is Dasha and Pekona, our [Warriors]. Well, I say [Warriors], but Dasha’s an [Axe Fighter] and Pekona’s a [Blade Dancer].”

The short, part-Dwarf woman and the young woman with the curved sword nodded to Toren, Pekona warily, Dasha still grumbling about the quality of Toren’s sword and arguing with Pekona. Insill whispered to Toren as he gestured to Dasha’s notable lack of height.

“She’s got a bit of Dwarf blood in her family. She’s part Terandrian, you see.”

Toren nodded as if she understood any of that. Insill pointed to the Gnoll next.

“This is Larr from the Hawkarrow Tribe.”

“Pleased.”

The Gnoll nodded, and Insill turned to the hooded, dog-like [Mage].

“And I am Anith. The [Mage] and party leader. I hope to work well with you, Miss Adventurer.”

He reached out and Toren gingerly mimicked his handshake. She must have done it alright, because Anith said nothing about it. He nodded to her mask.

“I wish that I could know your name, or identity. But I suppose your nature is a secret by choice, so I shall respect it.”

Toren bowed her head. And Anith nodded.

“He’s from the Duskclaw Tribe—Jackals.”

Insill explained as Anith walked forwards to break up the argument again. He grinned up at Toren.

“Oh, and I didn’t introduce myself, did I? I’m Insill. I’m the group’s [Rogue]. Notice the black scales? I can hide in the dark like a shadow, and I’ll be making sure we don’t run into any traps.”

Toren stared at him. Insill’s bravado faded a bit. He coughed and twitched his tail.

“So...shall we go?”

Toren walked with a group of adventurers in the middle of the dungeon. It was a novel experience, mainly because they weren’t trying to kill her, and she was only *contemplating* doing that to them.

The reason the adventurers were down in the dungeon was a mystery to Toren. She assumed they were here to...well, he didn’t actually know much about what adventurers did. That was a hole in her understanding of the world. They killed things, but for what reason Toren had no idea. She thought they might just do it because they were bored, and approved of the idea.

And none of them were about to tell her, even if Toren asked, which she couldn’t. The group of adventurers, known collectively as Vuliel Drae—which meant something to Anith and no one else—moved in silence. They let their [Rogue], Insill, take the lead and he carefully moved down the corridor, checking for traps and keeping an eye out for monsters as they slowly went from corridor to corridor, Anith mapping their route in his book.

It was boring, and not boring at the same time. Toren was bored by the slow progress, and the way that the adventurers let Insill check every tile and wall before moving on. She was bored by the way the Drake meticulously made Dasha shine her lantern down each corridor, and the

way Larr kept glancing behind in case of an ambush while Pekona scanned in every direction as if she was afraid of an attack out of one of the walls.

But she was delighted by the company, all the same. Real people, in the dungeon. Soon to be dead people, perhaps, but real people. And they thought Toren was one of them.

There was something...wonderful about that thought. Toren would have loved to explore the feeling, but then they came to a corridor and Toren saw the trap.

It glowed in her magical vision. The runes were shining across the entire hallway, some angled towards the group. There were runes on the ground ahead of Insill as the Drake cautiously advanced, and presumably they'd all fire if he touched them.

And the Drake didn't notice. Maybe it was because they were magical, and covered by the grime, or he'd just slipped up. Either way, Toren saw the danger and realized he was about to trigger them.

The skeleton thought fast. It was let the adventurers walk into the trap and risk getting damaged herself or stop them. So Toren moved. She dashed forwards as Insill was about to cross the first room. She reached out and *punched* Insill in the back of the head.

“Gah!”

He staggered, but Toren's hand pulled him back. The adventurers cried out as Toren whirled to face them. She threw her arms out as Pekona turned her blade towards Toren and Larr raised his bow.

“What the—”

“Hold, hold!”

Anith shouted to stop the others. He helped Insill up as the other adventurers stared hostilely at Toren.

“What was that for?”

Insill looked hurt and confused, the others suspicious. Toren hesitated, and then pointed down at the runes only she could see.

“What? What are—”

Insill came forwards, the others watching Toren. He pushed gingerly at the dirt on the ground with the tip of his dagger and then swore and leapt backwards as he saw the shining runes underneath.

“It’s a trap! I nearly walked into it!”

“*What?* How come you didn’t see it?”

Pekona stared at Insill. His tail wrapped around his leg as he hunched his shoulders.

“I don’t know! My Skill didn’t go off—”

“It might have been hidden by magic that nullified your Skill.”

Anith knelt by the runes, staring at them grimly. He looked up at Toren, and to the skeleton’s amazement, bowed his head towards her!

“You saved us. Thank you.”

The other adventurers reacted immediately. They lowered their weapons, looking ashamed. Dasha stroked at her chin, as if she had a beard. She was sweating a bit as she eyed the glowing runes.

“Dead gods, you did save us. Insill didn’t spot a thing.”

“Yeah, but—you didn’t have to hit me!”

Insill looked hurt. Instantly, Pekona whirled on him, looking irate.

“How else was she supposed to do it? She doesn’t talk!”

The Drake paused.

“Oh, right. But couldn’t she have tapped me on the shoulder or something?”

The other adventurers began venting their shock and relief on him. Dasha growled at Insill.

“You idiot! You’re our [Rogue]! Miss Swordswoman here had to stop you from getting us all killed! If you can’t detect a trap, then what good are you? I’ll kick your lights out myself!”

She smacked Insill on the arm, hard, stroking her bare chin furiously. Insill yelped and protested, until Anith told everyone to quiet down. Toren watched all of this with private glee.

Not only did she get to give other people the Lyonette treatment, but she got praised and other people helped her hit her victims? She was beginning to like these adventurers after all!

They went on. And it was now with Toren walking in the front, next to Insill. Her spotting that one trap had raised the adventurer's estimation of her, and so they both combed the corridor together before proceeding.

The last trap had shaken Insill's nerves. He would nervously stop to ask if she'd seen any traps every minute as they moved slowly down the corridors, and she would shake her head. The sheer act of checking the corridor and shaking her head filled Toren with a bit of happiness the skeleton couldn't explain. She was helping. But it wasn't her doing something alone. This was a *team effort*, and Toren had never been part of one of those before.

They ran into their first monster sixteen minutes after the trap. They'd just passed down a corridor when Insill raised his hand nervously.

"Wait a second. Something's not r—"

Ahead of them, a section of the wall opened up and a wall of white wriggling things poured out. Toren hadn't noticed the trap. Maybe it had been triggered from inside, but out the monsters came.

Hundreds of them. Thousands. A white mass of long, wriggling things. Toren hacked at them as the adventurers fell back, shouting.

They were leeches. They wriggled across the ground, searching for bodies. They ignored Toren, but she stomped on them and cut with her sword because she didn't want them messing up her clothes. The other adventurers were doing the same, cursing, tearing the things off as they tried to latch onto any skin.

"[Repulsion Barrier]!"

Anith shouted, and Toren saw a wave of leeches go flying away from him and Larr. But Pekona, Dasha, Toren and Insill were in the middle of it. They hacked and stomped until Toren heard Larr shout a warning.

"Watch out! There's the mother!"

Toren turned and saw the bigger leeches. They were far larger than the hand-sized ones that had come out in a wave. Some were as long as her leg,

others as long as she was. And one was half the width of the corridor and the sharp opening on the underside of its body was gaping as it lunged towards the adventurers.

Toren was in the way. She dove, but the mother leech must have identified the skeleton as a threat, for all Toren had no blood to suck. Grimly, the skeleton waited for the big leech to leap on her—it would be messy, but Toren would kill the leech if it tried to smash her into bits. But she heard a shout as someone leapt at the leech.

“Watch out!”

Pekona dashed forwards and cut into the giant leech’s side. Greenish-yellow blood spurted out from the slight wound. The leech turned, twisting towards the swordswoman but Pekona pirouetted and *spun*.

That was it. Toren watched, jaw agape as Pekona leapt and twirled, sword slashing down as the leech dove at where she had been. The [Blade Dancer] landed, twisted, and cut out, slashing another worm creature as it leapt towards her face. She spun, leapt again, and once more avoided the mother as it charged her like a bull.

Toren watched, entranced. She had never seen sword fighting like *that* before! But Pekona moved unlike any other warrior she’d seen. She didn’t hold her ground, but directed her opponent, attacking from odd angles, avoiding, rolling—

Like a dancer. Only Toren had never seen someone dance before. She stood up and charged the mother leech, hacking into her back, dodging back. Enraged, the giant leech turned to Toren. It gathered itself and leapt—

And he copied Pekona. Toren twisted, sprang. One hand touched the ground, and she cartwheeled through the air—

And into a wall. Toren’s momentum halted abruptly, and she fell back down.

“Watch out!”

Dasha charged into the mother from the side, hacking and cursing as more blood spurted. The other threw the part-Dwarf woman away with one shake of its body and turned to Toren. The skeleton got up.

Well, that wasn't it. She'd have to try again. But the mother was coming towards her. Toren didn't have time for fighting, not when she had something else to do. The skeleton stared at the mother in annoyance. Her body blurred—

And she flashed past the mother, a tear opening along the giant leech's side. It *keened* in silent agony as Toren stabbed it a few more times for good measure.

[Mirage Cut]. It had done the job. The mother died as Dasha got up and hacked it to bits from the other side. Insill, Larr, and Anith were finishing off the larger ones, and Pekona was still dancing among the leeches. None of them had touched her yet.

Toren watched her fight. Pekona twirled, and rolled, spun and cut. She didn't treat her sword as a thing that moved separately from her body; it and she were one. She moved to get around her opponent's flank, to strike at them from behind. Okay, that wasn't ideal for leeches, but Toren saw the way it could apply to almost any situation. It wasn't a single Skill or sword move; it was a way of fighting.

She admired that.

When it was over, Toren looked around and saw the adventurers staggering back, out of range of the remaining leeches who still wriggled determinedly at them through the guts and blood. Dasha was swearing, trying to unhook her armor so Insill could help her get the leeches that had crawled into the gaps out, and Anith and Larr were helping find the ones hidden in their fur.

"Dead *gods*. What kind of trap was that?"

"It was like a nest! Some kind of home for those things!"

"*They* triggered it. I'll swear it!"

The adventurers were babbling, upset. Toren was calm. It was just leeches. She could have killed them all herself, mainly because there wasn't much they could do to harm her, except for maybe crush her in the case of the mother. But she was surprised when they turned to her.

"Miss Swordswoman, that was pretty incredible! That Skill you used—was it [Mirage Cut]? That's a good one! You were fighting through all those

bloodsuckers as if you didn't fear a thing!"

Insill beamed at Toren, and the skeleton didn't know what to do. She turned away, adjusting her mask unnecessarily. Was it hot? No—why would that matter? Toren was *dead*! Then why did it *feel* hot?

"Not bad. I guess you are experienced enough to survive down here alone, huh? But what was with that crazy move where you ran into the wall?"

Dasha looked curiously at Toren. The skeleton hesitated, and then pointed at Pekona. Everyone looked at her. The young woman frowned.

"Wait, were you trying to do what I did?"

Toren nodded. Pekona shook her head, looking amused.

"I'm a [Blade Dancer]. It's not like a normal [Warrior] class, or like the [Blademaster] class. It's—well, it's a class from where I'm from. I don't think you can get the class just by copying the moves—there's an entire set of footwork and sword techniques unique to that way of fighting."

That was probably true. But Toren watched Pekona as she helped the others clean up. She didn't want the class. She already had a class like that. But why couldn't she copy Pekona? After all, she didn't have to have a Skill to have a skill. So could she learn to fight...without a class?

It was an intriguing thought. Toren waited until all of Vuliel Drae was ready, and they set off once more. The adventurers looked like a mess, covered in slime and blood as they were. Dasha was speaking as she poured a tiny bit of healing potion over a wound that wouldn't stop bleeding.

"I don't have it in me for another battle like that, Anith. That wasn't hard, but it was *disgusting*. I need an hour's bath, and I think there are still more of the things on me in places I haven't checked."

The Jackal Beastkin nodded.

"Nor I. But we should at least explore a few more corridors before we return. We haven't found much and we've only been here for an hour—"

Anith broke off sharply. Toren turned her head. Larr had heard it as well.

"Seems like our fight attracted something. There's a group coming."

The adventurers backed up, the warriors and Toren in front, Larr, Anith, and Insill in the back. They saw vaguely humanoid shapes, moving as Dasha swung her lantern out.

“Who’s there!? Are you friends or—”

Howls, deep and roaring, answered her. Toren saw the hulking bear-like not-Gnolls appear out of the darkness. And running ahead and around them were—

“*Goblins!*”

Yes, Goblins. Only these ones weren’t like Rags’ people. Toren stared at first. He stared at very pale green skin, glowing red eyes, and hunched forms. These Goblins were different. Smaller, more ragged, and far paler than their cousins.

Cave Goblins? Inhabitants of the dungeon? Then Larr spotted the not-Gnolls and shouted.

“By the tribes! What are *those*?”

It was a pity. Toren had hoped the Gnobli would know. She eyed the warriors. They were eight in total, and adding the group of Goblins there were over twenty monsters coming their way. Not all were armed; some Goblins had only their hands and rocks, but one of the not-Gnolls had a huge stone mace, carved so that the head looked like a screaming skull.

“Get ready! [Seeking Arrows]!”

Anith raised his hand and shining magical arrows shot from his open spellbook and finger. They struck the Goblins and bear-things, and Toren heard bestial screams. Three Goblins fell; none of the not-Gnolls did. They came on.

“[Triple Shot]!”

Larr felled one of the not-Gnolls with his Skill. Dasha ran forwards.

“Let’s go! [Impact Charge]!”

She smashed two Goblins aside as Pekona leapt forwards. Toren used her own Skill, [Daring Charge], and rushed into the group of monsters. Unlike Dasha, her Skill didn’t give her physical momentum, but rather

strength and speed. She cut a Goblin down and then slashed at the first bear-creature who struck at her with a crude mallet of stone and wood.

It was a battle, as the adventurers fought to push back the monsters. Insill was cutting at the Goblins, circling around and stabbing unguarded flanks as Anith used his barrier spell to keep others away from Larr and himself. Pekona spun and fought four enemies at once as Dasha fought with her back to a wall.

They were outnumbered, and perhaps, outmatched. If Toren hadn't been there, perhaps the adventurers would have died. But Toren was there, and so she killed.

A Goblin ran up and stabbed Toren in the back. She turned, beheaded the Goblin, and felt someone smash her in the back of the head. She staggered, turned, felt at her mask, and stabbed with her sword with the other hand. The not-Gnoll gurgled as Toren's sword found its throat.

The thing about clothes was—one of the not-Gnolls knifed Toren again and twisted the blade. Toren laughed silently and stabbed the creature through the chest. The thing about clothes was—a Cave Goblin slashed at Toren's arm but hit only cloth and bone.

The thing about clothes was, it made people think you could be hurt by mere *cuts*. Toren beheaded the Goblin and turned. The largest not-Gnoll was advancing on Dasha, despite Larr's arrows striking it from behind. It had that strange mace in its hands and as it raised it, Dasha grimly raised her axe to block.

The mace fell, and Toren heard a strange sound. It was a faint shriek, and it came from the mace. Then it struck Dasha, breaking her guard, battering her to the ground, and Toren heard the *scream*. It came from the mouth of the stone club, a wave of sound.

It was a deafening, horrible *shriek* that sent every adventurer—and the Goblins and other not-Gnolls—to their knees, clutching at their ears. The bear-thing with the club raised it triumphantly as Dasha lay on the ground, her plate armor bent. He aimed at her head to finish her off and Toren stabbed him in the back.

The not-Gnoll turned, small eyes widening in shock as it found Toren was still upright. It swung the club—but slowly. Toren heard the warning

shriek from the club and leaned back. The club passed over her head, and she cut at the leader's side. It snarled and swung with its own hand. But now Toren dove and rolled.

She came up, stabbed a kneeling Goblin in the back of the head, twisted, and spun away from the not-Gnoll's mace. It struck the ground and again the ear-splitting *shriek* filled the air. But Toren was unaffected. She leapt, and slashed, and the not-Gnoll holding the club howled in pain and fear as Toren landed and danced away.

“Get up! Get—”

Insill felt someone shaking him as he rolled on the ground, his head splitting open. He twisted, and saw Pekona, face white, ears bleeding. She pulled him up and he grabbed for his dagger.

“Behind you!”

Pekona turned. Insill threw, and the not-Gnoll staggered, the dagger in his chest. Pekona slashed twice quickly, and it fell back.

“We have to help her!”

“No—Dasha!”

Pekona pointed, and Insill saw their friend slumped on the ground. He ran towards her, tearing at his pouch. Pekona guarded his back as Insill frantically dumped the healing potion over Dasha's chest.

“Dasha! Speak to me!”

He lifted her up and felt one hand grab at him. Dasha gasped at him, face pale and bloodless.

“I'm fine! Get that monster before he uses the mace!”

“She's handling him! Pekona—”

Insill turned, about to suggest Pekona help, and saw the [Blade Dancer] standing with her sword lowered. She was staring at the mysterious adventurer, at Toren.

“Pekona?”

“Is she copying me?”

The young woman breathed the words in incredulity. Insill turned, and his mouth dropped open. In the middle of the corridor, a masked swordswoman dove and leapt, kicking off a wall to vault over the beast with the enchanted mace. Her sword flashed down, and she cut. The creature howled and stumbled.

“How?”

The other monsters were stirring. Insill grabbed Pekona.

“Ask later! Come on!”

It ended when Toren grew bored of the battle. She knew she could do it. She bent and dove and twirled, just like Pekona. It was a good way of fighting, and Toren felt she could do it again. But she was getting tired of having to avoid the not-Gnoll’s wild swings, so she positioned herself so her back was towards the other adventurers and used one of her secret weapons.

For just a second, the skeleton’s eyes blazed purple. They shone brightly in her mask, as the not-Gnoll raised its mace for a swing. The beast froze as the [Fear] spell struck it and Toren leapt forwards. She rammed her blade into the creature’s chest, and it choked. It fell, grabbing at the blade and Toren pulled her sword out. She turned, and saw the battle was over.

The last two Goblins were fleeing; the other not-Gnolls were dead. The adventurers stared at her, and Toren saw Pekona staring at her with wide eyes. Only Insill spoke.

“Wow.”

In the minutes that followed, several things happened. Larr and Anith bent over Dasha, making sure the healing potion had cured the worst of her injuries. That done, they went over to the not-Gnolls to confer.

“I’ve never heard of a species like this. They almost look like you, L—”

“They do *not*.”

The Gnoll snarled at Insill, making the Drake back away with hands up. Anith stared grimly at the dead bodies.

“We should take one of their heads. I know Liscor isn’t offering a bounty on any monsters killed in the dungeon yet, but this is important.”

“I’ll do it.”

Larr bent and began sawing at a head with a dagger. Dasha, now on her feet, turned and spat weakly as she saw the grisly sight.

“Can’t believe you lot do that.”

“It’s not like Terandria, Dasha.”

Insill turned to her, looking defensive.

“We don’t have truth crystals, so adventurers can’t prove what we kill. We *need* to take proof, and in this case—”

“Yeah. Got it. Don’t mean I have to like it.”

Dasha turned away. She blinked as she saw Pekona slashing with her sword, twisting her body and slashing at the air.

“What’s she doing?”

“Teaching Miss Swordswoman her style.”

Insill pointed. Dasha murmured quietly.

“By my beard.”

Pekona leapt and spun, moving from position to position, assailing an imaginary foe. She went through basic strikes, moving into advanced rolling slashes and ways to leap from walls, or vault through the air after a handspring. And Toren copied her.

It wasn’t effortless. The skeleton had to think hard to figure out how to move. But Toren’s body moved exactly as she willed it, and what was better, she didn’t *forget*.

Toren was a good watcher, because she didn’t blink. Within a few minutes she had memorized every move the [Blade Dancer] had made, and

was trying it out herself. The other adventures stopped and stared as Toren and the young woman turned, pivoted and slashed with their swords in a curved, graceful arc with the exact same timing.

By the time Larr straightened with the not-Gnoll's head, Pekona had stopped, panting heavily. She stared at Toren with a mixture of admiration and fear.

"You're no normal [Warrior], are you. Are you Gold-rank...? Some kind of prodigy?"

Toren just shrugged. Pekona stared at her and shook her head.

"You saved us back there, so this is the least I could do. I don't know if you'll get the class—but if you do, please don't tell me. I couldn't bear to be passed up by someone who can copy everything I do just by watching."

She turned, sheathing her sword. Toren watched as Larr went to confer with Anith, and as the adventurers hesitantly approached her. The Jackal nodded to the bodies.

"We didn't recover much. But that mace—it's good loot. And we've taken enough damage as it is. We only came down here to survey the area, and we're in agreement that it's far too dangerous to continue. We're heading back."

Toren nodded. She followed the group, still thinking about all the sword techniques Pekona had shown her. When the group stopped in front of the hole in the ceiling, Toren was surprised to see the ropes hanging down. But then—how else would they have gotten down? She stared curiously at them as the adventurers argued at the base of the hole. Dasha seemed to be in a heated argument with Anith and the rest, but then she reluctantly bowed her head. They approached Toren again, and this time she saw the mace they had taken from the dead leader of the not-Gnolls in Larr's hands.

"We think you should have this. You saved us not once but twice. If you're willing to sell it, we'd gladly split the costs, but if not...we'll earn something for the information from us exploring the dungeon anyways."

Dasha looked bitterly disappointed, and Toren saw Insill's eyes on the mace. She eyed it, took it from Larr, and lifted it up. Toren could manage to lift it thanks to her [Lesser Strength]. She swung it once, and the

adventurers *winc*ed as the mace shrieked as it cut through the air. Toren shrugged and handed it back to the adventurers.

Larr looked flabbergasted.

“What? You do not want it? But it is worth much coin, yes?”

What was coin to Toren? She couldn’t use it. She shrugged and waved a hand at the mace. If she couldn’t swing it fast, it wasn’t worth anything to her.

“Thank you.”

Anith turned towards Toren and bowed his head. She stared at him as he went back towards Dasha, asking whether she would need help ascending or if she could manage it on her own. And Toren felt...conflicted.

She could have stabbed him in the back. She could have plucked out Anith’s eyes. She could have—

But *she* wasn’t going to. For some reason, Toren was reassured by that knowledge. She didn’t need to kill these adventurers. They were an asset. Like *his* undead.

What a strange thought. But the [Blade Dancer], no, Pekona had taught her new things. And they had offered her a share of the treasure.

It wasn’t as though Toren *had* to kill them. She could make an exception. And so, for the first time, Toren did. She turned away, and walked back into the darkness. And she felt good. Something was in her head, a curious thought.

They thought she was Human. They thought she was alive. They thought she was someone who would help them, be their friend. And Toren had been.

Just like Erin.

Just like Erin, how about that? Toren had done it. For a few seconds...

She’d been just like Erin. The skeleton walked back into the darkness, that tantalizing thought in her head.

Insill was the one who saw the mysterious adventurer leaving.

“Wait! Where are you going?”

He cried out as she began to walk away. The other members of his group turned in alarm. But the masked swordswoman who’d saved their party didn’t come back. She turned to face Insill, and lifted one hand.

She waved at them and pointed back into the dungeon. Insill cried out.

“You can’t be serious! Come back! It’s too dangerous—”

But she strode away. In moments, she was gone. Insill turned back to his group. The [Rogue] was in shock.

“I can’t believe it. She just fought two battles and she wants to go back? She’s *insane!*”

“She’s got the Skills. I didn’t see her use a healing potion after either fight. And she noticed the traps—”

“Even so! Any normal adventurer would go back and rest, right?”

“Maybe she knows she can keep fighting.”

Anith spoke quietly. He nodded at the place where the mysterious adventuress had been.

“When we first met her—in the moment before you called out, Insill, I was afraid. My [Dangersense] went off when she still thought we were foes. If she had attacked...she is clearly of a higher level than we are.”

“No doubt. But I can’t believe she could find that trap when Insill couldn’t!”

“Maybe she knew where it was already?”

“Yeah, but if she did—how did she find it to begin with? It still doesn’t make sense! Does she have two classes that are both high level?”

“Surely not!”

“How’d she make it past all the traps, then? You were as surprised as me to see her! If she didn’t come down by rope—and there weren’t any signs anyone was here before us—then how?”

Struck by the thought, the team of Vuliel Drae looked at each other in silence. Either the mysterious female warrior had made her way down the hole into the dungeon by herself—and they hadn't seen any traces of someone entering before them—or she'd gotten past the trapped rooms already by *herself*.

“Beard blight, you don't think she actually passed through those trapped rooms and got down here...alone?”

Dasha's face was pale as she stroked at her smooth chin. Larr shook his head.

“She's already gone. We can ask once we reach the city, but we are still in danger here, no?”

That was true. The adventurers began to prepare to ascend the ropes, tying themselves in so they wouldn't fall all the way to the ground if their hands slipped. Insill mechanically grasped his own rope as he looked into the darkness of the dungeon. He thought about the female swordswoman, how mysterious she was, and wished he could have looked under her mask. Was she injured? Had some accident damaged her throat, and that was why she didn't speak? Or was there another reason?

He wondered if he'd ever meet her again.

The adventurers left the dungeon. They were the first to come exploring for treasure, through this shortcut. But they would not be the last. And they brought an artifact, and hope of more rewards to kindle the hearts of those seeking fame and fortune.

And so above, the rumor spread of a mysterious swordswoman, someone who had braved the dungeon of Liscor by herself. A Named Adventurer? Unlikely, but possibly a solo Gold-rank adventurer, a rival to Griffon Hunt and the other Gold-rank teams converging on Liscor.

The tale was simple. Down in the dungeon, there was a [Swordswoman], no, some kind of genius [Blademaster], solo adventurer with a mask, who fought alone for fame and glory. If you met her, she would fight by your side and guard your back. It was a beguiling thought

for those who feared the monsters below. Somewhere, down there, there was a friend in the darkness.

A friend who would see you home.

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4.09

Zel Shivertail sat in the Tailless Thief, the most famous and well-reputed inn in Liscor and felt out of place. Partly because he really didn't care for the inn, and partly because of the stares.

Inns were a subjective experience no matter where you went, Zel found. They were ostensibly just places to eat and sleep, but any real inn managed by a proper [Innkeeper] quickly developed...personality. It grew a community of clientele, and generally reflected the owner's attitudes.

One way in which that was apparent here was in the clientele of the Tailless Thief. They were all Drakes. There was not a single Gnoll or Human to be seen, much less the rarer species that lived on Izril. No matter where Zel looked, he only saw scales.

That wasn't a bad thing in general, but it was in a city where the population wasn't solely Drake. And it wasn't as if non-Drakes were barred from entering either. It was simply that they weren't *welcome*. And people felt that and stayed away.

Zel could have used a non-Drake crowd about now. He moodily sipped at his mug, filled with the spicy Fireshot drink. Non-Drakes were pleasant to be around because most didn't know who he was. They didn't *stare*. But what Drake child hadn't heard of Zel Shivertail, the Tidebreaker, hero of both Antinium Wars? And in Liscor of course, Zel's name was spoken just as often. This was where General Sserys had come from, and Drakes did not forget their heroes.

The [General]'s hand tightened around his mug. Yes, this had been Sserys' home. Now Antinium lived here, among the citizens. What would Sserys have thought of *that*? Zel wondered. At the very least, he thought Sserys would have hated the attention as much as Zel did. The [General] usually tried to keep a low profile when he visited other cities for this very reason.

Not that the person sitting across from him was helping Zel remain inconspicuous. Wall Lord Ilvriss, one of the sworn protectors of the famed Walled Cities—in his case the city of Salazsar—sat expansively in his chair,

sipping from some elegant drink or other and delicately spearing morsels from his plate with the long-handled fork the Drake aristocracy loved to use.

“And you’re sure the Human said Ryoka Griffin, Shivertail?”

“Positive.”

Zel stared in dismay at the delicate, glistening fried eel on his plate. He pushed it away and sighed. Where did you *get* eels in the winter? But of course the [Innkeeper] would have the finest food for the Wall Lord and a Drake [General]. It had probably been run here overnight by Courier.

“Interesting.”

Ilvriss nibbled at his fork, carefully consuming a morsel of meat—seasoned Corusdeer, the local specialty—simmered in a ragù for added flavor. Zel knew this because the innkeeper had told him what he was eating in detail. And at length.

Ilvriss finished his bite and patted at his mouth with a napkin. He frowned, thinking.

“I have instructed my contacts to inform me the instant this Ryoka Griffin is spotted. If she does return to the city, I will know of it within minutes. But I am not content to wait. I would go north to seek her out if it were not for the situation with the Antinium, but I cannot find any information about this blasted Human. She is not a Courier—or if she is, no one has compiled any records of her, and they are meticulously updated. And no one I have spoken to has heard of her!”

Zel grunted. He took another swig of his drink and glared at Ilvriss.

“That’s because you only asked *Drakes*, you idiot. If you want to find a Human, you talk to Humans.”

Ilvriss flicked out his tongue in displeasure.

“Humans lie.”

“And you think Drakes don’t?”

“I have more faith in my own kind than I do in others, Shivertail.”

“You’re a fool, then. We didn’t lose half of the continent to Humans a few thousand years ago because we get along *well*.”

Ilvriss’ tail *twitched*, but he didn’t reply to that. Instead, he flicked his fork at a map that lay on the table between the two.

“From what I have heard, the Goblin Lord has been spotted around the Blood Fields. He is retreating from the two suppression armies sent after him. They have advanced with nothing but victories over the disorganized Goblins.”

“Is that good news?”

Zel stared at the map. One of the few reasons why he travelled with Ilvriss was the Wall Lord’s access to a network of informants Zel couldn’t be bothered to maintain. Ilvriss raised one nonexistent eyebrow.

“You really think this Goblin Lord is a threat? There are *two* armies heading towards him, Shivertail. Each one led by a [General], each one nearly ten thousand strong.”

“And that’s supposed to reassure me? This Goblin Lord...is a Goblin *Lord*, Ilvriss. He beat back the army you and I were leading together with ease. Now, I might have had a lot less than ten thousand soldiers at that point, but that’s still two [Generals] by my count—and a lot higher level than the ones heading towards him now.”

Ilvriss shrugged, his tail flicking dismissal.

“Your army was exhausted from battling mine, Shivertail. It was smaller, and I might add, less well-equipped.”

“So you keep saying. But I think it’s dangerous. If those idiots ruling from their safe cities listened to me, we’d be sending a force twice that large, and I’d be leading it.”

The Wall Lord sat up a bit, nettled by Zel’s tone.

“You place too much faith in a Goblin’s ability to fight, Shivertail! The real threat on this continent are not Goblins. They’re a nuisance. The Antinium and those blasted Humans are our enemies.”

“And each other.”

Zel glared at Ilvriss. He could see a [Barmaid] with a refill out of the corner of his eye. She was afraid to get close, and for good reason. Both Ilvriss and Zel were using intimidation Skills unconsciously, and their argument was emptying the inn around them.

“Goblins are as dangerous, Ilvriss. Or have you forgotten the second Antinium War already? We were having a great time trying to kill each other. Us, the Antinium, the Humans—and the damn Necromancer—when the Goblin King appeared and started kicking everyone’s collective tail.”

“We killed him.”

“Only by uniting! If there hadn’t been so many armies fighting him at the same time—Ancestors, Ilvriss, don’t you realize what a threat a single Goblin Lord could be? They’re the equivalents of high-level [Generals] and a King...”

Ilvriss shifted. He looked uncomfortable, perhaps because he realized he was wrong.

“No matter the danger, a Goblin King is a single threat. Once he is slain, the threat dissolves.”

“It’s not that easy. We got lucky last time.”

Zel was blunt. His tail was wrapped around his chair leg, squeezing tightly in vexation. He jabbed a claw at Ilvriss.

“Go read some history, Wall Lord. Read about what happened when the Goblin King before the last one appeared on Terandria. He brought down *eight* kingdoms and ended at least two bloodlines that stretched back thousands of years!”

Ilvriss was silent. He stabbed at his plate and bit into another piece of meat.

“We shall see what occurs. This Goblin Lord is still the lesser threat. I want to know what the Antinium are doing here, and why the Slayer and the Small Queen are meeting.”

“You and me both.”

Zel clenched his fist. Ilvriss nodded.

“Focus your attention on *that*, Shivertail.”

“I’d have an easier time if you’d at least visit the inn I keep telling you about.”

“Bah. A Human inn. I’d rather bathe in filth. I can’t imagine why you stay there. I keep telling you, I will *pay* for you to stay here, where you can at least reside in relative comfort.”

Ilvriss’ tail curled up in disgust. Zel shook his head as the innkeeper, Peslas, hurried forwards with a refill for him.

“I actually prefer it over there, to be honest.”

Peslas and Ilvriss both gaped at him. Zel eyed the eel and wished he’d insisted they eat at The Wandering Inn for lunch. The Drake [Innkeeper] looked as if he were about to faint. Ilvriss looked outraged.

“You cannot be serious. You’d prefer Human cuisine over this? This is the finest Drake cooking outside of a Walled City, Shivertail!”

“I like pancakes.”

Zel also liked the little Gnoll furball who would beg for scraps and sit on his lap like Selys used to. But he didn’t say that out loud. Ilvriss stared at him, and then turned towards Peslas.

“[Innkeeper]. Bring me your finest cut of Corusdeer steak, seasoned, cooked medium-raw. And a plate of Ssarish for appetizers.”

Peslas bobbed and hurried into the kitchen, shouting for his [Cook]. Ilvriss pointed his fork at Zel like a sword.

“You have lost your mind, Shivertail. I’ll at least get you to acknowledge proper Drake cooking.”

Zel raised his claw.

“That’s not necessary. I’m not hungry for this, really—”

“I insist.”

Zel groaned internally as Ilvriss clapped his hands and a [Barmaid] hurried over with another glass for him. Why did he travel with Ilvriss again? He put his head in his hands and wished he were somewhere else.

And a few miles away, running through the snow, Ryoka Griffin finally spotted her destination.

“There it is. See it, Ivolethe?”

The young woman running through the snow exclaimed as she crested a hill and spotted the inn in the distance. She was tired, footsore, and foot *cramped*, since she was wearing boots. She would have preferred to run barefoot, but the snow was far too deep and cold for that. She was very cold, tired, and she’d had to sleep outside last night.

But she was close. Oh, so close. Ryoka Griffin grinned as she spotted The Wandering Inn in the distance. She was nearly back.

Something swooped down and alighted on her shoulder. Ivolethe glanced towards the inn in the distance and nodded.

“I see it. And I have seen it for the last five hours as I flew. What is so special about *you* seeing it?”

“Oh shut up. We’re almost there.”

Ryoka swatted at Ivolethe and caught only air. The Frost Faerie backflipped off of Ryoka’s shoulder. She flew slowly by Ryoka’s head, talking with the girl as Ryoka ran on.

“We could have been to the city far faster had the clumsy driver not run over the brigands. ‘Twas entertaining, but costly, was it not?”

“You’re telling me. But Reynold says Magnolia has orders to turn every [Bandit] he spots into road kill. Jeez, she doesn’t play softball, huh?”

“She does not play games of throwing at all, unless they are edged things.”

Ivolethe agreed absently. She looked up and flew high, chasing after something. After a few minutes she returned, a bird's feather, freshly plucked, in her hands. Ryoka glanced at her.

"I'm going to have a lot to do when I get there, Ivolethe."

"So ye have said. I shall entertain myself."

The Frost Faerie shrugged. Ryoka stared at her.

"So you're going to be okay by yourself? And you're *not* going to harass Ceria or make trouble for Erin? You're going to be cool?"

"I am *always* cool. I am cooler than ye shall ever be."

Ryoka stared at Ivolethe and nearly face planted as her foot slipped going down a hill. The faerie laughed at her and sighed when Ryoka glared.

"I *promise* not to bother the wh—your friends. But you must make good on your promise too!"

"I'll leave you with a stack of gold coins so Erin feeds you until you turn into a balloon."

It was a good thing faeries were so easy to bribe. Ryoka smiled to herself as she ran on, the faerie chattering about what she'd have Erin make her to eat. She was nearly back. It had been long—so very long! It felt like forever since she'd been at Erin's inn. The last time she'd seen Erin, the girl had been in Celum. But now Ryoka was coming back. And she could tell Erin everything that had happened. She could—

Could...

What would she say to Erin? Ryoka frowned. She'd tell her everything, of course. But how would Erin react to the news about Magnolia, the [Assassins], the discovery that there was someone else from their world nearby? Laken the [Emperor], and Blackmage in Wistram! How would she react if Ryoka told her about that night with the three strangers at the campfire?

How much did Ryoka really know Erin, anyways? She knew a bit about Erin's past, she'd done a lot with Erin of course—she'd gone to find her when Erin had disappeared, and they'd had some laughs together. But now, coming back, Ryoka was suddenly struck by a bit of uncertainty. Because she felt like a stranger again. She knew Erin.

But she didn't feel like she *knew* Erin. Not after all the crazy things that had happened recently.

Ryoka felt a bit of fear worm its way into her stomach as she reached the foot of the hill that led to the Wandering Inn. It was silly. She'd run away from horrible nightmares in the darkness, things Ivolethe refused to talk about. She'd braved a blizzard, survived an [Assassin] attack, and talked down a hostile half-Troll girl who could have squished her with one hand. So why was she afraid of meeting an old friend?

Maybe it was because Ryoka didn't really know how to meet old friends. That word was a foreign concept to her. What should she do? Should she—

Caught up in her thoughts, Ryoka didn't hear the crunching in the snow until a blur appeared on her left. She turned, alarmed, and saw something coming at her from the direction of Liscor. Some strange blur that was kicking up snow. It was too low to the ground to be visible as it raced through the deep snow at Ryoka. She backed up. And then it leapt *at her*.

“Holy—!”

A patch of the snow seemed to launch itself *off* of the ground and smashed into Ryoka's midriff. The girl shouted as the impact knocked her down the side of the hill, tumbling, rolling, struggling with the creature—person—child—

“*Mrsha?*”

The Gnoll licked at her face, slapping Ryoka lightly with her paws as the cub tried to climb all over Ryoka. Ryoka laughed and yelped at once, trying to grab Mrsha. But the Gnoll was a blur. She grabbed at Ryoka, hugging her tightly, making small sounds that weren't words.

"Mrsha! Relax! I'm glad to see you. It's okay. I'm here. I'm glad to see you too!"

Ryoka finally found a bit of fur and grabbed it. Mrsha latched onto Ryoka, hugging the girl so tightly her paws dug into Ryoka's skin through her coat. Ryoka hugged her back, whispering to the trembling Gnoll child.

"I'm sorry. I was gone for a long time. But I'm back, see? I'm back."

She didn't try to prise Mrsha away, and the Gnoll wouldn't have let go for anything. Ryoka sat up awkwardly in the snow. Only then did she realize she had company.

Four tall Gnolls stood watching her and Mrsha in the snow. They might have been male, or female. It was hard to tell. But they were tall, adult, and watching her. Ryoka's stomach lurched a tiny bit.

"Uh, hi."

Thought and fear raced ahead of everything else. Why were they here? Were they worried she was trying to attack Mrsha? Or was it because Mrsha had white fur? Were they after Mrsha? Where was Erin? But then one of the Gnolls spoke and put Ryoka's fears to rest.

"The Mrsha child smelled you and ran to find you. We came to ensure she was not in danger."

"Oh. She came from the city? Wait, what was she doing there?"

One of the Gnolls, the tallest, nodded. He had red-brown fur and had a sheathed axe at one hip.

"She was with Krshia for lessons when she scented you. She knew you were coming long before we smelled you."

"Oh. I get it."

Mrsha had a stronger nose than any Gnoll adult due to her youth. Ryoka felt Mrsha shift her grip as she clung to the young woman. She was licking

Ryoka and nuzzling her head against her. It was intimate, but Ryoka felt awkward in the presence of the other Gnolls.

“Well...she found me. Do you all need anything?”

The Gnolls stared at her. They had a strange intensity about them. The lead Gnoll pointed at Ryoka, eyes searching her face.

“You have returned with what honored Krshia needs, yes?”

Ryoka stared up at the reddish-brown Gnoll as Mrsha tried to coat her face with saliva. What they—oh! The book! It had been so long since she’d made that promise that Ryoka had nearly forgotten. But she’d carried it with her in the bag of holding all this time. She nodded.

“I—yes. I’ve got it with me. I can give it to her—”

“Good.”

So saying, the Gnoll reached down and grabbed Ryoka’s legs. She froze.

“What are—”

Another one seized Ryoka from behind. She yelped and began to twist, but it was hard to with Mrsha clinging to her.

“Wait, what are you—”

The Gnoll lifted her *up* into the air as if Ryoka were a feather. She yelped and twisted, but suddenly found herself gripped from below. One Gnoll had her legs and buttocks, another her back. They began running with her carried over their heads, helpless, as Mrsha hopped up and down on Ryoka’s stomach, making noises of excitement.

“Hold on! Hold *on*—put me down! I have to—I’ll give it to Krshia in a bit, okay? Put me down—Mrsha! Stop moving!”

The Gnolls didn’t listen. They had a tremendously strong grip and try as she might, Ryoka was in no position to get free. They began to run with her held above them like a log. Ryoka yelped, but suddenly she was moving *fast* down the hill, straight towards Liscor!

“Put me down! Put me *down*!”

No one listened. Ryoka hollered, but Mrsha was delightedly climbing on Ryoka's front, and the girl had to grab her to make sure she didn't fall off. Liscor came into sight, and then Ryoka was headed straight for the gates.

The [Guardsmen] on duty stared at Ryoka as she passed by, borne aloft by the small crowd of Gnolls. She shouted at them to help, but they were too busy laughing to do anything.

Zel Shivertail stared at the proffered plate of Ssarish. It was a traditional Drake dish; sliced meat, very thinly cut and served raw or cooked depending on the area. It wasn't a bad food and Zel enjoyed it at times. He knew the Gnolls did something similar, although in their case they chopped their meat incredibly finely and mixed it with a light mustard sauce.

This dish of Ssarish was lightly sprinkled with olive oil, garnished with a bit of white, crumbly cheese, and delicately brushed with a mixture of lemon, salt, pepper, and some spicy greens Zel didn't recognize. It wasn't that it had been made poorly either. In fact, the problem was that it had been *overdone*. Zel would have liked a plainer Ssarish, if he was even hungry for the stuff.

Which he wasn't.

"I'm not hungry, Ilvriss."

"Have some of the steak, then. This is Drake cooking—and I will have you enjoy it!"

"Drakes don't have a monopoly on *steaks*, Ilvriss."

"We invented them."

"We invented a way to *chop meat*."

"You are neglecting to include the art of seasoning food. This is properly spicy, nuanced flavor—"

“Just because some of our kind can breathe fire, it doesn’t mean I want to do it myself!”

Zel snarled at Ilvriss. The Lord of the Wall glared at him across the table as the innkeeper, Peslas, hovered in the wings, ready to dash into the kitchen and bring more food out for Zel to try. The [General] sat at the table, arms crossed, tail lashing the floorboards.

“I told you, I’m sure the cooking is fine. But I don’t want any right now.”

“I *insist* you try a cut of the steak.”

Ilvriss sliced into the rich meat, still steaming with heat. Zel sighed, but the Drake lord’s sense of pride meant he had to try some. Or run. Zel weighed the odds of Ilvriss chasing him down and reluctantly picked up a fork. He speared a juicy chunk of the steak and chewed it down. Peslas, Ilvriss, and a number of Drake patrons in the inn waited with bated breath.

“It’s good.”

Zel had to admit, the hot spices and rich meat was a good mouthful. Peslas exhaled loudly and Ilvriss treated himself to a smug smile. Zel raised one claw.

“But. I’ve had better lunches. And I could be eating one right now if you’d let me go.”

“Nonsense!”

A fist pounded the table as Ilvriss raised his voice in outrage. He speared a piece of the steak and waved it at Zel.

“This is prime dining here. You will have your lunch with me—”

“I don’t want steak, Ilvriss. It’s not as if this is the greatest steak in the world, and I’m not a fan of your company.”

“This is the finest dish you could order in Liscor—”

“*In* it. But the inn I go to is a bit out of the city’s limits. And I bet the innkeeper there could make me a steak as good as this one.”

Ilvriss furiously chewed the steak, as if mastication could prove Zel wrong. He gulped it down and pointed at it triumphantly.

“Aha! There you are wrong. I can detect the quality of the dish, and this is excellent fare for one of the lesser cities on the continent. The owner of this inn, Peslas here, is to be commended for it.”

He nodded graciously at Peslas, who beamed and bowed his head towards Ilvriss. The Wall Lord pointed at the dish as he addressed Zel as if speaking to an infant.

“This was made by a cook with *[Advanced Cooking]*! No Human [Innkeeper] could—”

“She’s got *[Advanced Cooking]* too, Ilvriss. And her food is new. She makes this thing called a ‘pizza’, which is quite—”

“I will not hear of it! Peslas! Another dish! Bring me—yes, bring me some sautéed shrimp! The same dish you served me last night! As you will see Shivertail, no *Human* innkeeper could provide you with quality seafood in the winter.”

“I don’t want seafood! I want to go!”

Zel stood up. Ilvriss tried to hold him down, but Zel was quite a bit larger than the Wall Lord. Still, Ilvriss was tenacious. The two Drakes were struggling at their table when they heard the shouting.

“—*down now!* I am not happy! I’ll walk—hell, I’ll *run!* Just stop carrying me like this! Do you hear me? Stop grabbing—Mrsha! Don’t jump on my stomach! Hey! *Hey!*”

Both Drakes turned. Someone was shouting quite loudly. Ilvriss scowled.

“Humans! They’re noisy even when they aren’t in the room!”

He let go of Zel and strode to the open entrance of the inn, probably to yell at whomever was making the noise. Zel went too, intending to make his own break for it when he saw the Gnolls.

There was a crowd of them, running through the street. But that wasn’t what made both Drakes’ jaws drop. It was the young Human woman they were carrying over their heads. She was struggling, yelling, as the Gnolls held her over their head and ran with her. Everyone in the street was watching, some laughing, others pointing or scratching their heads in

confusion. But that wasn't what made Zel's blood run cold. It was recognition. He knew that Human. He knew her name.

Ryoka Griffin.

She was being carried by a group of Gnolls as they ran down the street. Zel stared. He saw someone else perched on Ryoka's stomach, happily staring around as if this were an exciting new experience.

"Is that—Mrsha?"

He turned to Ilvriss. The Drake's scales had gone pale. He had recognized Ryoka too. And the Lord of the Wall's reaction was immediate. His hand went to his sword, and he unsheathed the shining blade. Zel took a step back.

"Ilvriss. Hold on—"

Ilvriss' normal look of bored contempt had vanished. He stared after the group of Gnolls as they rounded a corner. Then he turned and shouted at the room full of Drakes. At his adjutants, the group he'd brought with him.

"After that Human!"

The Wall Lord charged out of the room. Zel cursed as a number of Drakes who'd been silently waiting against the walls charged after their lord. He ran after Ilvriss, shouting for the Wall Lord to stop.

A few minutes after they'd gone, Peslas hurried out of the kitchen with a plate of sautéed shrimp. It was good stuff, but as even Ilvriss would have conceded, the [Chef] had let the shrimp go just a tad bit undercooked.

Krshia was waiting in her apartment when Ryoka was shepherded into the room. A crowd of Gnolls came after her, spreading out around the apartment which grew significantly more occupied. Some stared or sniffed and wrinkled their noses at the smell of rot in the air—but it was better than it had been. Brunkr stared at Ryoka as he kept a bandage slathered with honey over his arm. He glanced at Mrsha, but the Gnoll was too busy sitting

on Ryoka's shoulders and nuzzling her head to pay attention to anything else.

Ryoka halted as she saw Krshia look up. The [Shopkeeper] looked like Ryoka had last seen her, if a bit more tired. She smiled when she saw Ryoka, though. With expectation—and fear.

“Ryoka Griffin. You have returned, yes? At last. And you have brought what was promised, I hope?”

She stared into Ryoka's eyes. The young woman nodded slowly. She was aware of the Gnolls in the room who weren't Krshia or Brunkr, and how they stared at her. Her, and Krshia.

Ryoka's mind flashed back to the past, to what she'd learned before she'd left Liscor, weeks ago. It was Krshia's clan who lived in Liscor. They had come to earn money, to prove something. And to gain something valuable to offer to the tribes when they met.

They had stockpiled spellbooks, tens of thousands of gold coins' worth. And it had all been lost when Lyonette used a powerful artifact to destroy Krshia's shop by accident. Ryoka had promised to give them something of equal value in return for Lyonette's life.

And Krshia was afraid she hadn't got it. Or she hadn't got something her people would consider good enough.

“You have it with you now?”

Krshia was watching Ryoka very carefully. The girl nodded. She reached for her side, for the small bag of holding she kept tied securely there.

“I went to a...friend. A powerful [Mage], rather. I convinced them to give me something, a spellbook that would make up for what you lost.”

Behind his aunt, Brunkr stirred.

“*One* spellbook?”

Around the room the Gnolls muttered. Their voices were too quiet for Ryoka to hear, but Mrsha's ears perked up and Krshia shook her head.

“One may do. If it is the right one.”

She sounded like she was trying to convince the others. Ryoka nodded, trying to appear confident.

“This isn’t just *any* spellbook. Look.”

She put the bag of holding on the table in front of Krshia, and then bent to reach into it with both hands. She had to use both hands, not because the spellbook was heavy, but because it was too *big*.

Enchanted to be as light as a feather. Big as...big as Mrsha. The Gnolls *gasped* as one as Ryoka lifted the spellbook Teriarch had given her out of her bag of holding. Krshia’s eyes widened into round circles. Ryoka grinned like a madwoman.

It had been too long. But now here it was. Some days she’d almost forgotten about it, but now Ryoka remembered vividly. A spellbook. Not just any spellbook, but one given to her by Teriarch.

Taken from a Dragon’s hoard. A book of teaching from another age, filled with magical knowledge.

A gift from a Dragon.

“By the tribes. What is *this*?”

Krshia bent over the huge spellbook as the other Gnolls gasped and crowded around the table. Ryoka opened her mouth to reply and got a paw in her face as Mrsha climbed over their heads to see. She gently took Mrsha off her head and cradled the Gnoll in her arms. Ryoka thought of how to explain and said one word.

“Worth.”

All the Gnolls looked at Ryoka sharply. She smiled.

“This will settle the debt.”

“Alone? It is a magnificent work, but by itself...”

Krshia hesitantly placed her hands on the tome, opening it, staring at the gilded letters—and illustrations!—in the book. The Gnolls around her were murmuring quietly, perhaps debating that very thing. But Ryoka shook her head.

“This is equivalent, Krshia Silverfang. Equivalent to fifty or a hundred lost spellbooks. For you see, this *isn't* a spellbook.”

“It isn't?”

Krshia looked up sharply. Ryoka smiled. She stood taller and pointed down at the tome, speaking with a voice that carried around the room. You had to sell what you had, even if it was worth more than diamonds.

“I didn't bring you a simple spellbook with a handful of spells! No, this is a proper *instructional tome*, something that actually explains how spells *work*. You'd be lucky to find this in *Wistram*, let alone a normal [Mage]'s library! It's a first-edition tome of Rihal, and it contains every spell they knew from Tier 1 to...I think Tier 4. It might be *the* most valuable thing you will ever see in your life.”

Every Gnollish eye stared at Ryoka. There was a pregnant pause, and then the room exploded into excited babble. Gnolls crowded around the book, fighting to see, but afraid to touch. They sniffed at it like Mrsha. But Krshia only had eyes for Ryoka, as did some of the older Gnolls. One spoke to her.

“If what you say is true...”

“It is. Every word. I swear it.”

Ryoka met his eye—or her eye—squarely. She knew some Gnolls like Krshia could detect a lie. The Gnoll hesitated.

“You would be willing to swear upon a truth spell?”

“Any time.”

The Gnoll blinked. She looked back at the tome, and her ears shook.

“Incredible. It is a dream. And it is *true*.”

Krshia spoke sharply.

“The knowledge of this will not leave this room, no? No one will speak of it! And it will be guarded, yes, guarded this time by [Warriors].”

All the Gnolls looked at her. Some bowed their heads, others nodded. Ryoka sensed it. Whatever power struggle Krshia had been fighting

through, it was over in a flash. This was worth, pure and simple. More worth than the Gnolls of Liscor had possessed before, and they all knew it.

Krshia turned to Ryoka. There was jubilation in her eyes, but also wariness.

“This is a gift worthy of a [King], Ryoka Griffin. We owe you a debt for it. But you say it came to you from another? Do we owe a greater debt that must one day be paid?”

Ryoka hesitated. Here it was. The Gnolls were watching her again. So she thought back to her conversation and decided on the truth. You couldn’t lie so easily in this world. But half-truths were easy.

“It is a debt, but the one who is owed will never call on it. You owe a debt of gratitude to an incredibly powerful magic user, the equivalent of an [Archmage]. His name is...uh...well, it’s Teriarch.”

She hoped using his name wouldn’t be a problem. But no one knew it, right? And if it was spread, well...Teriarch was vain. She heard other Gnolls murmuring the name.

“I convinced him to be a patron of your tribe. And I gave him something of equal value to the book.”

“You gave him something? How?”

“I cannot say. But it was worth it to him. It was a fair trade, I swear it.”

The young woman met Krshia’s eyes, praying Krshia did not ask more. Because Ryoka couldn’t explain iPhones and Teriarch’s magic and the simple generosity of a Dragon in front of the others. The Gnoll stared for a while at Ryoka and nodded.

“Then I will believe you. But this gift...it is too much.”

What now? Ryoka almost groaned to hear it, but the other Gnolls were nodding. Krshia looked at Ryoka as she ran a paw over the tome regretfully.

“It is too much for a gift, even one to repay a debt. You must ask something of us in return, or it will not be fair. And this debt is too great for us to carry now.”

She wanted Ryoka to ask, but she didn’t have anything to pay with. Ryoka’s mind raced. She stared at Krshia, imagining all kinds of things,

good and evil and petty and grand to ask of her. But then she thought of who she'd come to Liscor to meet. She looked at Mrsha, and realized some questions were trick questions, even if the only person doing the tricking was yourself.

She smiled at Krshia. The Gnoll watched her warily. Ryoka took a breath and spoke her price.

“Friendship, Krshia Silverfang. That is what I desire.”

The Gnoll blinked at her. All the Gnolls did. Ryoka turned to them, looking them in the eye. She finished last on Mrsha, who was touching the tome excitedly as Brunkr tried to push her paw away.

“This is a gift of friends, and the cost is paid in intangible things. I offer it in the name of friendship, with you and your tribe, if you will accept it.”

Krshia stared at her. Ryoka thought she saw the Gnoll smile slightly, and then she took Ryoka's hand. She squeezed it tightly, and then let go.

“So it is said! We are friends, Ryoka Griffin. And we will remember this gift for as long as our tribe endures. No—Gnolls will remember this. I promise you. Your name and that of Teriarch will be spoken as long as we endure. We do not forget.”

Ryoka felt a chill as Krshia said that. It was more than an honor. It was terrifying, what the Gnoll said. But it was also heartfelt, and it made Ryoka feel as though she had touched immortality. To never be forgotten.

And then it was business again. Krshia bent over the tome, and beckoned Ryoka over. The other Gnolls respectfully gave her room. One of them lifted Mrsha off the table, and Krshia was bombarding Ryoka with questions about the book.

“You say it teaches, yes? So that a novice may learn? I have never heard of such a thing, but perhaps it is a lost way of making such books. Where and when was this nation—Rihal? It must be important, but I have never heard of it. You said the book comes from here, yes?”

Ryoka scratched her head. The conversation with Teriarch was an age ago. Had he ever...? No.

“I have no idea, but I'll swear the book is genuinely from that place.”

Krshia nodded. She paused on a page and traced the writing.

“Ah. See. On this side, there is magical writing. On this—not. It is a written language.”

Surprised, Ryoka bent over the book.

“You can tell?”

“Yes. One is rooted in magic and looks different from other angles. The other...no. It does not change. And it is not magical. It is something [Shopkeepers] learn, to tell the difference to identify fraud.”

Fascinated, Ryoka stared at the writing. There was a tiny illustration, of some kind of flower blooming. Was this a spell to grow plants? She stared at the magical writing, but she was in too much of a hurry to start decoding it.

“It must be. This is an instructional guide, so it might be describing the spell’s effects, or how to use it best.”

“Worth.”

Krshia echoed the word, and then growled softly.

“But I cannot read it! And no one living knows the language, or so I am thinking. But a spell—yes, I need an artifact.”

She turned and snapped.

“A pair of lenses, enchanted with a translation spell. Someone find one and bring it to me!”

At once several Gnolls rushed out the door. Ryoka glanced at Krshia.

“Do you think it will work?”

“The spell does not need meaning, only time. It...how do you say? It decodes the language. Identifies it over time to attain mastery. Now, Rihal. Perhaps there are books with the name—”

Krshia was turning to some other Gnolls when Ryoka heard a brief howl from outside. It was short, upset, and cut off abruptly. Instantly, every Gnoll in the room, including Mrsha, went still. Someone ran back up the stairs and thrust open the door.

“Honored Krshia, there is trouble below!”

One of the Gnolls who'd left spoke to Krshia as the Gnoll turned towards the door. Krshia glanced towards Ryoka, and the girl wondered if someone had followed her. Or the Gnolls?

"What is it?"

"There is a group of Drakes below. They are armed. And they want Ryoka Griffin."

Everyone stared at Ryoka. Krshia looked at the young woman.

"Have you enemies among the Drakes, Ryoka?"

"I don't know! I don't think so—I have a long list, but I'm fairly certain Drakes aren't on there!"

Ryoka went to a window, but Brunkr pulled her back. She blinked at him. He growled softly.

"Be wary. They might shoot into the windows and Aunt has neither glass nor spelled wards."

Ryoka nodded and backed away. Krshia looked around. The Gnolls in the room were tense, and Mrsha was staring around wide-eyed.

"They would not be openly bearing arms if they were entirely peaceful. This must be handled without bloodshed. We go out together. Ryoka in the middle. Move."

The group exited the room, Gnolls streaming out, to the audible dismay of the Drakes below. Then Ryoka came out, Krshia and Brunkr at her side. The wounded Gnoll had taken off his bandage of honey and was holding a sword in his good hand.

Ryoka stopped when she saw the group of fourteen or so Drakes. They were all armed, all dressed in fancy clothing—hardly as if they were ready for a fight. She didn't recognize any of them, but they looked well-armed. Then her eyes fell on the two standing at the front of the group. One was large, a bear of a Drake as big as Relc. He was arguing with another Drake who was shorter, slimmer, and dressed in regalia fit for a [King]. He turned to Ryoka and his eyes fixed on her.

"*You.*"

The face didn't give anything away. But the instant he spoke, Ryoka's mind went back in time. She remembered the tone, and now the haughty posture. She remembered a battlefield, a tent—her stomach lurched as she recognized Ilvriss now.

“Uh oh.”

Ilvriss strode towards her as the Gnolls formed a wall in the way. Zel Shivertail walked next to him. But Ryoka's eyes were on Ilvriss. She knew why he was here. Because she remembered.

She remembered how his lieutenant had died.

Memory.

The undead are approaching, terrible giants clawing out of the ground. A monster—some kind of armored Gnoll in front, a massive battleaxe in one hand. A creature of rot walks beside him. She calls herself Bea.

They are coming. My eyes want to bleed at the sight of them. They are horrors far more terrible than a zombie or lesser undead. The servants of Az'kerash approach.

But she does not run. The Drake commander holds her ground, and the elite warriors who have come with her ready themselves. They'll die here. I know it. She knows it too.

I look to Periss.

“You'll die. Run.”

She looks at me, just once, and shakes her head.

“Drakes do not run. Go!”

My feet take me away as the soldiers charge. Sixteen against a horde. Kerash raises his battleaxe with one hand and Bea spreads her arms wide. I turn and pump my legs, running past zombies and horrors that reach for me.

The screaming begins in only seconds. I hear the sounds of death, of flesh being torn and bones breaking. But I hear the living shouting in defiance as they charge the dead, fighting to the last. But falling.

One by one.

Ryoka felt her knees go weak. The smell, the feeling of terror and panic, all of it struck her at once. One second she was there, the next she was in the past. She stared at Ilvriss as he advanced, bare sword in hand. He barely seemed to notice the Gnolls, although the other Drakes with him were eying the Gnolls nervously. Ilvriss stopped a few feet away from the group surrounding Ryoka. He stared coldly at the Gnolls.

“Move aside, civilians.”

No one budged. A mocking voice came from the group of Gnolls.

“We are simply standing here, Drake. Is that a crime?”

Ilvriss gritted his teeth as he stared at Ryoka. Her mind was racing. Run? No. It was safer here. What did he want to do with her? What could she say?

“I wish to speak with that Human. Move.”

“On whose authority? You could be anyone. Fancy clothes do not make rank among Gnolls, although they do among Drakes, yes?”

There was laughter among the Gnolls. The laughter died in an instant when he turned his head to look at them. Ryoka felt a sudden surge of fear. For a second Ilvriss was taller, and his eyes burned—she had to fight off whatever Skill he’d used. By her side, Mrsha was whimpering.

Ilvriss’ voice was cold as he spoke. It rang out across the street.

“I am Wall Lord Ilvriss, and I will speak to that Human on a matter of war. If you will not move, I will consider you all my enemies.”

There was a visible *shift* in the ranks of Gnolls when they heard his title. But Krshia spoke up, sounding unafraid.

“Wall Lord or not, she is a free visitor to Liscor. It would not be good for Drakes to detain an innocent person against their will, no?”

The Drake stared at her. Krshia grinned. Only the people close to her could see how her paws were shaking a bit by her side.

“We are citizens of Liscor. If you would harm us, you would make an enemy of the city, yes? And Ryoka is my friend.”

“I do not have time for games.”

Ilvriss shifted. He might have been raising his sword, or turning to order his people, Ryoka didn’t know. She took a step forwards and raised her voice.

“Wall Lord Ilvriss. I’m right here. If you’ve got something to ask me, why not do it now?”

He looked at her. It was just one look, but Ryoka felt it shoot right through her like an arrow. There was fury and other emotions in the Drake’s gaze. She felt pinned. Ilvriss stared at her and opened his mouth.

“I have only one thing to ask you, Human. What happened to Periss? What happened to my lieutenant? How did she die?”

The street went still. Everyone was staring at Ryoka, even the Gnolls, even Mrsha. Ryoka felt her mouth dry up. A thousand answers floated through her mind, but only one found her tongue.

“I can’t tell you.”

Ilvriss blinked. He stared at her, filled with fury.

“What?”

Ryoka’s mouth was on autopilot. She recited automatically from the Runner’s handbook, remembering a passage she’d read long ago when she’d first started running.

“Runner’s confidentiality. I cannot reveal who I deliver to, or what was delivered to any other party without permission from my client.”

She waited for the Wall Lord’s response as her mind scrambled to keep up with what she’d said. Ryoka saw Ilvriss’ eyes flash, and he made a

garbled, *hissing* sound of incoherent rage. He seemed to be unable to process her response on a physical level.

“You dare—a technicality! Answer me! *How did she die!* Tell me or I will—”

He tried to stride forwards but the Drake standing next to him, Zel, grabbed him. The Gnolls backed up as the two Drakes struggled and swore and the other Drakes rushed forwards. Ryoka’s mind was whirling. Her thought process went something like this:

If I tell him, he dies. If I tell him, I’ll die. If Az’kerash finds out—could he? What could he do to me from here?

I can’t risk it. Not until I think about consequences. But that’s the last thing Ilvriss wants to hear. So how do I get out—

Relief came when she heard shouting. Actually, crippling fear came first, but it was relief when she saw Watch Captain Zevara striding forwards with a group of [Guardsmen]. She put herself between Ilvriss and the group of Gnolls, although she didn’t look happy to do it.

“Wall Lord Ilvriss, please withdraw! You cannot bear arms in the city or threaten civilians!”

“Move aside, Watch Captain!”

Ilvriss threw off Zel’s hands and snarled at Zevara. She hadn’t drawn her sword, and she backed up a step as Ilvriss advanced on her. He pointed at Ryoka.

“That Human is hiding information! Information about my lieutenant and my soldiers and how they died! I will have it from her!”

Zevara turned and looked at Ryoka. The Human girl was sure the Watch Captain had no idea who she was, but Zevara turned to Ilvriss and put a hand on her sword.

“Whatever the issue, I cannot let you abduct a Human by force. Not in the city. The laws are clear—there would be an incident with the Human cities if we were found—”

“I do not *care*.”

Ilvriss raised his sword and the [Guardsmen] drew their weapons. Zevara braced herself and opened her mouth *wide* for some reason. Ilvriss snarled as he looked at Ryoka and she braced. Then everyone heard a shout.

“*Pan attack!*”

Ilvriss’ head turned. Ryoka’s head turned. She saw a black blurring object, flying towards the Wall Lord’s head. Ilvriss twisted. His hand shot out and he grabbed the spinning object before it could strike him.

It was a frying pan. In the silence, everyone stared at it. A black, cast-iron frying pan. Ilvriss stared at the frying pan in his hand, a confused look on his face.

“What the—”

The second frying pan clocked him on the head. Ilvriss staggered but didn’t go down. He turned, snarling, and then saw the adventurers.

They assembled in the street, some holding weapons, others just standing there for visual effect. Three groups of adventurers, although Ryoka couldn’t know that. She only recognized Halrac, Ceria, Pisces, Ksmvr and Yvlon. The rest of the adventurers were a mystery to her. But once she saw who was leading them, it all made sense.

Three teams of adventurers stood behind a girl who held a third frying pan in her hand. Griffon Hunt, the Halfseekers, and the Horns of Hammerad. The Drakes might not have recognized any of the groups on sight, but they could identify seasoned warriors at a glance.

“Someone call for trouble?”

Jelaqua Ivirith grinned as she held her two-handed flail. Revi grimaced as she stood yawning next to Typhenous.

“We’re not bodyguards! Why are we here?”

Typhenous chuckled as he posed with the staff in his hand.

“We weren’t doing anything, and this is entertaining, isn’t it Revi?”

Ryoka didn’t hear Ilvriss cursing, or Zevara shouting for the adventurers to back off. She walked out of the group of Gnolls as hands seized the Wall Lord before he could leap at her. She looked at the young woman who was walking towards her, a huge grin on her face.

They met in the center of the street. Ryoka saw the young woman's smile, and heard her voice.

"Hi Ryoka. What's up?"

A thousand things to say. A thousand ways to reply. Ryoka cleared her throat awkwardly. She tried to smile, and found it was actually very easy. She looked into Erin Solstice's eyes and weakly returned the girl's grin.

"Hi Erin. I'm back."

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4.10

This is what Pisces saw. He stood in the snowy street, facing down one of the Drake Lords of the Wall and his personal retinue. By his side stood Zel Shivertail, one of the most famous [Generals] in the world. To Pisces' right and left, two Gold-rank teams, the Halfseekers and Griffon Hunt were facing them.

Perhaps it was only he who was slightly incredulous that this scene could take place. Pisces had grown up reading tales of heroes fighting in armies, facing down Dragons and slaying monsters. But he had never believed he'd see a scene similar to that.

And oh, for what a petty reason they'd gathered! Pisces glanced at the tall young woman, the Runner who had attracted Wall Lord Ilvriss' wrath. Ryoka Griffin. She was hardly important in the grand scheme of things. What reason, what *right* did she have to change the world in this way?

But perhaps it was her. Pisces turned his head and stared at a girl who truly did defy explanation. Erin Solstice. There was something she had that made her unique. Perhaps not something she had. Somewhere. Perhaps it was the where of her origins that did the trick.

Pisces didn't know. He understood everything else in the world, but Erin he didn't. That irked the young man, because he prided himself on his knowledge. It was a type of magic in itself, knowing things, knowing secrets.

That was why among all the tense and glaring warriors present, some gripping their weapons with steady grips or wearing expressions of bravado, Pisces was the one truly calm head. Or so he believed. He was busy glancing around, noting each of the groups gathered here. Krshia Silverfang and a good deal of Gnolls had gathered in this spot around Ryoka. Now, why would they do th—

Someone poked him. Pisces jumped. He turned and saw two pale yellow eyes glaring at him. Ceria hissed at Pisces in a low voice that only he and the other Horns of Hammerad could hear.

“Don't get distracted! Stay ready!”

She was tense, and Pisces could see particles of frost and snow swirling around her skeletal hand. Ceria clearly thought they might have to fight. Pisces disagreed.

“Calm yourself, Springwalker. I don’t believe it will come to violence.”

“Don’t believe—*she hit him with a pan!*”

“Yes, well...”

Pisces could only shrug in reply. The problem with Ceria was that she never educated herself, and there was never time to explain things properly in situations like these. She went around acting the same way, not taking into account local laws and customs. If she had, then she might be more relaxed.

Calmly, Pisces turned and watched the Watch Captain, Zevara, start shouting at Erin while Zel Shivertail forcibly restrained Wall Lord Ilvriss. It looked bad, but it wasn’t going to erupt into violence unless something went truly wrong. And Pisces knew that because he actually read Drake law. He was probably one of the foremost non-Drake experts in the world on the subject.

The Wall Lord was in the wrong in every way here, and he knew it. If he turned things into a conflict, it would be the Watch Captain’s duty to stop him. The adventurers Erin had brought were simply a reminder of that fact.

And while Erin had definitely attacked him, Pisces also knew how Zevara would react. Which is why he smiled triumphantly as the altercation in the street came to a swift close. Zel Shivertail forcibly dragged Ilvriss back until his retainers could calm him down, the Gnolls left the street after escorting Ryoka to Erin. And the innkeeper?

“A fine? Aw, come on...”

“You struck him, Human! Don’t argue! Four gold coins. Give them to Relc—give them to *Klbkch* and don’t argue or I’ll double your fine!”

Zevara was practically breathing fire; wisps of smoke were leaking from the corners of her mouth. Erin grumbled, but the Watch Captain didn’t wait for a response. She stomped away and then the [Guardsmen] left too.

The [Necromancer] nodded to himself in satisfaction. A predictable result. Really, it was just about knowing how people would react based on a

certain set of variables. The Watch Captain was predictable...at least, where it came to Erin. She knew that Erin had the Antinium on her side, and so she was disinclined to start another incident.

Still, four gold coins was vindictive. A single gold coin would have been harsh for starting a brawl. The Watch Captain must have been extremely angry, which spoke to the aberrancy of this situation.

Soon, Erin was hurrying back to the inn with Ryoka. Mrsha was in the Runner's arms, and the three adventuring groups broke up. Revi was still grumbling.

"We have *things to do*. How much do we have to do for this [Innkeeper]? Honestly, that obnoxious Drake innkeeper might have been rude and charged a lot, but at least he didn't bother us."

"I didn't hear you complaining at Christmas."

"That was fun. This is work, and we're doing it for free."

"Revi, don't start."

"I didn't join this group to do work for free, Ulrien! If we're going to keep helping Erin, we should at least be paid for..."

Pisces listened with half an ear as Revi, the Stitch-girl [Summoner], argued with the rest of her party. Her response was predictable too. But he had better things to do in this crucial moment where everyone's guard was down. Pisces stared hard across the street. He could still see Ilvriss arguing—screaming, really—at Zel. They were too far away of course, but happily they were both standing across from each other, so Pisces could see their mouths moving. And that was important to Pisces for one particular reason:

He could read lips.

It would hardly be a great surprise to anyone who knew Pisces that he had that talent. Not a Skill in fact; Pisces had mastered the art of lip reading to avoid wasting a Skill on such a mundane ability. And it had been oh so useful in Wistram, especially when his ability to eavesdrop with his undead creations had been discovered.

Everyone always thought that he, the [Necromancer], had only one particular skill. But Pisces was a [Mage] as well. He had specialized his class in one field of magic—and then gone back to study every other field

as well. Pisces sneered at the idea that a truly great mage had to be limited to one class. A true [Mage], or so he felt, specialized in as many classes as possible.

Yes, a great [Mage] was a [Pyromancer], a [Seer], an [Alchemist], a [Sword Mage], a [Warlock], a [Druid]—although Pisces was leery about getting tattooed. And any true mage, any true purveyor of knowledge and secrets had to have other skills as well.

Secrets were worth much even outside of Wistram. And a secret shared between a Wall Lord and a [General]? Oh, so very precious. Pisces' eyes narrowed as he deciphered part of the Drakes' conversation.

“I'll take care of it. You cool your...”

“Ask her! So help me Shivertail, if you...if I have to go to war...”

“I *know*. I know.”

The two broke away from each other. One of the Drakes accompanying Ilvriss handed something small to Zel and he nodded at the Wall Lord. Pisces casually glanced away as Ilvriss began storming down the street, the other Drakes following him. Only Zel hung back. He slowly began to walk in the direction of the Wandering Inn.

Curious. Pisces stroked his chin as the adventurers began heading back to the inn as well. What did ‘I'll take care of it’ mean? Clearly, Ryoka was important to the two Drakes, but the Wall Lord was particularly interested in her, it seemed. He'd threatened her with steel, against Watch Captain Zevara's explicit orders. He would never normally do that, Wall Lord or not.

Pisces was aware of Drake politics, and a Watch Captain was second to none in her own city when it came to matters of law and order. She could only ever be overruled in military matters by a soldier of equivalent or greater rank to a [Colonel], and certainly not by a foreign lord.

“Ryoka's back. Do you think she got the magical items appraised?”

Pisces focused back on reality as he heard Ceria speaking anxiously. Ah, yes. The magical artifacts. Pisces cleared his throat. He didn't know whether Ryoka had them either, but his observations could only improve the general understanding of his group.

“I surmise that if she had the items, they are stored in the bag of holding at her belt. Given the limited opportunity she had to visit Invril, I would imagine it is unlikely she would have returned without some knowledge of the magical artifacts.”

“I know that.”

Ceria nodded, but she seemed relieved to have been reassured.

“She said she appraised them. But she also said she might have to sell some. I wonder...”

“Captain Ceria, I am unsure of the protocol regarding adventuring in groups. Should I express my dissatisfaction with Ryoka or general avarice at this point?”

Pisces’ lips quirked and he turned his head to avoid smiling at Ksmvr. The Antinium was far too amusing to belong in his Hive, which was probably why he’d been kicked out. Ceria paused and Pisces saw a peculiar expression on the face of the woman who was walking as far away from Pisces as politely possible.

Yvlon coughed and scratched absently at her bare forearms. At first glance, they looked like they were covered with some metallic liquid. Then it became clear that the metal was fused *into* her arms, melded with both flesh and bone. Yvlon’s affliction intrigued Pisces every time he looked at her. He had no little amount of sympathy for her either; she had received those injuries defending all of them from a fire construct. It was a shame he couldn’t use his skill with bones to fix her, but there wasn’t enough of her bone left unscathed for him to work with.

Perhaps if she’d let him experiment with adding someone else’s bone to hers. But Yvlon would never hear of it, so Pisces hadn’t bothered to suggest. She hated necromancy, and thus barely tolerated him.

“Ksmvr, you don’t have to do anything. Magical items are important it’s true, but in my experience, the best adventurers don’t fixate on them. I’ve seen too many teams torn apart fighting over the loot from an expedition to count.”

The Antinium with three arms absorbed this information slowly, nodding his head.

“I see. I will commit this information to memory. However, I assume we will wish to speak with Ryoka Griffin in the near future?”

“If we can. Looks like everyone wants a piece of her.”

Ceria groaned. And that was certainly true. When Pisces got to the inn, the first thing he heard was Erin’s voice.

“Okay everyone, form a line! Anyone who wants to speak with Ryoka can wait in line. Uh, send just one person if you’re a group. Krshia wants to talk first, and then Klbkch—hey Klbkch, your mean Captain says I have to give you money. And Zel said he wants to talk too. And then—oh, Ksmvr?”

Ksmvr strode into place right behind Zel and Klbkch. He flinched as the Revalantor of the Free Antinium stared at him, but Klbkch said nothing. Zel looked unhappy to be surrounded by Antinium, but his desire to speak to Ryoka clearly outweighed his emotions. He stood stiffly with both arms folded. Klbkch looked equally unhappy to have the Drake [General] behind him. Pisces nearly burst out laughing when he saw Klbkch and Zel fidgeting. How could no one see the humor in that situation?

But he refrained from laughing and just nodded towards Ksmvr as the Antinium waved to Pisces and the other Horns of Hammerad from his place at the back of the line.

“Commendable, I must say.”

Pisces said that appreciatively as he took a comfortable seat at one of the tables. He waved at Lyonette for a drink and something hot to eat while he waited. Pisces smiled to himself until he noticed Ceria and Yvlon glaring at him.

What? *What?* Oh, did they think he was being sarcastic? Pisces rolled his eyes. He had merely been expressing his gratitude that Ksmvr would stand in line for them, despite his stated issues with Klbkch. Why were people so fixated on believing the worst of him?

In any case, the break gave Ceria and Yvlon time as well, and they spent that time worrying about what Ryoka had discovered in Invril. Pisces spent his time far more frugally. He devoted a pleasurable few seconds ordering what was on tap from Lyonette and receiving a small bowl of fried

potato strips he quite liked. And all the time he watched Ryoka talking with the people in line.

He couldn't see Krshia speaking with Ryoka, but he got a good view of Ryoka's lips as Klbkch approached. Pisces paused, watching the young woman's lips carefully as he bit into a french fry.

"I told Magnolia."

Pisces' eyes narrowed as he watched Klbkch nod, reply, and walk swiftly out of the inn. He couldn't read the Antinium's lips—since he didn't have any, only mandibles. But this was curious too. What had Ryoka told Magnolia and why would it involve Klbkch the Slayer of all people?

After Klbkch came Zel Shivertail. Now Pisces was *really* interested. He tried to focus on Ryoka's lips, but the Drake was blocking the way. Pisces hissed under his breath and reached into his robes. Time to try another tack.

Something crawled out of a hidden pocket Pisces had sewn into his new robes and onto his hand. He didn't react, but carefully lowered it to the underside of the table. Pisces felt it crawl off and casually reached for another fry, not looking down at the ground. He didn't have to; he could sense what was happening.

Quickly, a small spider began to scuttle down the table leg, onto the floor, and towards where Ryoka was seated across the inn. It was a Shield Spider, or rather, a Shield Spiderling. A baby spider, newly hatched.

And it was dead. In fact, it was undead. Pisces had found the spider a long time ago and figured out a way to reanimate it using his magic. It was an extraordinary achievement in the field of [Necromancy] for him—he hadn't thought he *could* animate non-mammalian species until now. No one had appreciated that of course, but that was all to the better now. Because Pisces could see and hear what his creation did.

The undead Shield Spider scuttled quickly across the floorboards. Pisces tried to shield it from anyone's view, keeping it in the shadows, running along the wall. Fortunately, all the adventurers were busy having a late lunch. Pisces had been worried Halrac, the keen-eyed [Scout] might see, but the man was too busy arguing with Revi. Thank goodness for loudmouthed [Mages]. Pisces detested them the most.

Nearly there...Pisces sat up in anticipation as his Shield Spider moved two tables away from Ryoka and Zel. He could hear them talking, faintly.

“...I am simply asking how...benefactor?...won’t give up...”

That was Zel’s voice. The spider scuttled closer. Pisces could see through its multiple eyes Ryoka and Zel’s feet. He heard Ryoka reply after a pause.

“I can’t tell you.”

“May I ask w—”

Something suddenly *smacked* the spider sideways, sending its view tumbling around in chaos. Pisces nearly leapt out of his chair. He looked over and saw a white ball of fur, crouched in the exact place where his spider was.

Mrsha! Pisces saw her tail wagging. He nearly stood up before he caught himself. Instead, he sent quick signals to his undead creation. The spider fled towards a table, but Mrsha leapt after it.

Drat the child! Pisces watched in horror as Mrsha chased after the fleeing undead spider. He desperately tried to get the young Gnoll’s attention, but Mrsha was oblivious as she cornered the Shield Spider’s corpse. With all the inquisitiveness, thoughtfulness, and brutality of an innocent child, she smashed the tiny spider into the ground and then sniffed at the remains.

The spider was gone. Pisces couldn’t control it, or hear anything else. He slumped in his chair, wanting to bury his face in his hands. All that work. No one knew how *hard* it was to animate a spider compared to a Human corpse, let alone put listening and vision spells on it! But she hadn’t known. Yet he’d been so close to hearing something worthwhile!

“Too bad about that.”

Pisces glanced up. Ceria was staring at him across the table. He frowned.

“Excuse me?”

The half-Elf nodded her head very slowly. She stole one of Pisces’ fries and licked at the salt on top before chewing it thoughtfully. She kept her

voice very low as she spoke directly to Pisces.

“Next time, you should enchant it with something to make it faster, more durable, or smell bad. Otherwise Mrsha will just destroy it. She likes small moving things, unluckily for you.”

He stiffened and opened his mouth to deny the truth or to lie, but Ceria just looked at him. She pointed to where Ksmvr was patiently waiting at the head of the line. Zel was standing up, looking dissatisfied.

“We’re up.”

Pisces stared at Ceria, and then got to his feet. He reflected that while he saw much more than most, he had to be careful himself. Because other people were watching *him*. He wondered whether Ceria thought she was on his side, or if she was warning him. It didn’t matter. Pisces had no side.

He was, and always had been alone. Friendships were fleeting, and alliances were simply the prelude to betrayal. Pisces knew he should expect less than nothing from his new party, this reckless endeavor known as the Horns of Hammerad.

And yet, he did like them, even Yvlon. Imagine that.

Ryoka sat in Erin’s inn, a drink of hot, lemon-flavored sugar water in front of her and a bowl of salty fries by her right hand. It was easier to eat fries with her right hand while she used her left hand to lift the cup. Her two missing fingers on her right hand made Ryoka’s grip feel uneasy and lopsided whenever she lifted something remotely heavy.

That wasn’t what she should be focusing on. There was so much to do, so much to think about! Now that Ryoka was back in Liscor, it seemed like everything was happening at once.

First Krshia, then Ilvriss. Now Klbkch. Ryoka watched as the Antinium strode out of the door. She couldn’t say much to him in the inn, not with everyone around. But he got the message. Magnolia knew of his intentions.

What would Klbkch do now? Ryoka would have loved to talk it over with him, but now came another problem.

Zel Shivertail sat down across from Ryoka and gave her a brief smile.

“We meet again, Miss Runner. My apologies, it’s Miss Griffin, isn’t it?”

“Ryoka is fine.”

Ryoka stared at him warily. She barely recognized the huge Drake. But she remembered his voice. She remembered the second-to-last last time she’d seen him, in a dark and misty forest and soldiers fought and died around them. He’d been lost, until Ilvriss had arrived and everything had gone to hell.

She’d seen him two other times as well. Both times Zel had been leading a charge. First, on Ilvriss’ camp as Ryoka had run away in the chaos. The second time, against the Goblin Lord as the Stone Spears tribe and Ryoka had been fighting for their lives.

The young woman’s throat constricted as she remembered the thousands of Goblins killing the Gnolls, overrunning Zel’s army. She glanced away from Zel, towards Mrsha. The Gnoll was happily following something on the floor.

Zel followed Ryoka’s gaze.

“I remembered you and that Gnoll cub. Funny—I could have sworn she had brown fur before, but then I only got a short look at you while I was trying to kill that damn Goblin Lord.”

Ryoka paused. She looked at Zel. He’d been courteous to her before, more so than Ilvriss. But she didn’t know the first thing about him. But at least on this subject, being honest might help.

“She did have brown fur. It turned white after the battle.”

After she lost her tribe. Zel looked at Mrsha and shook his head. He looked melancholy. Was there affection in his eyes as he stared at Mrsha? Why?

“So some of the rumors about white fur among Gnolls is true. I had no idea their fur could change color, though. Mrsha certainly gets into enough trouble without needing bad luck.”

“Uh yeah. I heard you helped save her once. Thank you.”

It felt odd. Ryoka was caught between the impulse to profusely thank Zel and the incongruity of it. She wasn't Mrsha's parent. But she was her guardian, the only one the Gnoll had left. She should have been there.

More guilt. Zel shook his head casually.

“Anyone would have done the same. But perhaps you can return the favor? I'm sorry about earlier, but you might have guessed that Ilvriss came to Liscor looking for you.”

Ryoka's heart began to beat a bit faster. She kept her tone casual as she watched Erin buzz about the room, serving food, talking with people. How had her inn gotten so busy? The last time Ryoka had been here, it was practically deserted except for a few visitors. But now she had two Gold-rank adventurer teams staying here? *And Zel?*

“I did notice. Mind telling me what he wants?”

“He wants to know what happened to his lieutenant. Periss. She ran after you in the battle in the forest and never returned. Ilvriss thinks you had something to do with her going missing.”

Cold spikes of fear ran through Ryoka's stomach. Here was something else she hadn't had time to think about. The same argument ran through her head. Az'kerash, the legendary Necromancer was ranked about equal to Teriarch on Ryoka's list of people she didn't want to piss off. And if she told people where he was hiding...

Zel spread his claws out on the table.

“Let me tell you what I saw, back when we first met, Ryoka. I met on a battlefield. Well, I saw you earlier after you'd sent Ilvriss' camp into chaos. I still have to thank you for that. Without that advantage my side might have lost the battle.”

“Was it an important battle?”

Ryoka stared at Zel. The [General] shrugged, looking slightly bitter.

“Important for some. It was a squabble between one of the Walled Cities and a coalition of city-states. If I'd have lost, there would have been

trouble, the cities might have had to become vassals or pay tribute or some other nonsense...but nothing tremendously terrible would have occurred.”

“And that’s why you’re with Ilvriss now? Because you’re all buddies after the war?”

Zel bared his pointed teeth in a grin.

“I hate his scales. But he wanted to know what happened to his lieutenant and I thought it was curious too. Because—and I’ve gone off track—I saw you during the battle. Aside from the fact that you managed to either defeat Periss and a dozen elite [Soldiers] or lose them—which some Couriers would have trouble doing—there was the battle with the Goblin Lord.”

“Yeah. That.”

The [General] stared at Ryoka.

“I’m sorry about that Gnoll tribe. I did all I could to save them, but that Goblin Lord—did you know he was in the area?”

Ryoka’s hand clenched on the edge of the table.

“I had no idea.”

“I thought so. But you saved Mrsha.”

“One of them. Just one.”

“More than I could with an army. The rest of the tribe went down fighting. Every last one of them.”

Zel sighed. Ryoka felt as if she’d dropped through the floor. She reached for the hot drink Erin had given her and took a sip. It felt like she was drinking death.

All of them. An entire tribe. That was Ivolethe’s price.

Ivolethe. Ryoka turned her head. The faerie had vanished after the Gnolls had grabbed her. She might not have wanted to interfere, or known Ryoka wouldn’t be in trouble. Where was she...?

There. She was riding on Mrsha’s head, laughing as the white Gnoll cub snuck up on something on the floor. Ryoka felt worried until she

remembered that Erin's inn was built with copper nails. Ivolethe was free to enter and exit here without danger.

"I'm sorry. I shouldn't have brought it up."

Ryoka started. She glanced at Zel and saw him looking at Mrsha. He shook his head.

"I don't want to burden you. It's just that I saw you using that potion—or was it an artifact—after the battle. You ran faster than I've ever seen anyone go. And then during the battle—I saw you freeze your way *through* part of the Goblin Lord's army to get away. You were running like a Courier then, too."

The Frost Faeries. Ryoka opened her mouth and then closed it. Zel eyed her calmly.

"Please understand, I'm not accusing you of anything. I am simply asking how you did all that. Do you have some kind of benefactor who supplies you with magical items? Did you have to defend yourself? Is that how Periss died? Ilvriss won't give up until he knows the truth behind her disappearance."

Hesitation. Ryoka looked down at her hands. Her two missing fingers. She took a deep breath.

"I can't tell you."

"May I ask why not?"

How could she answer that? What was the safest way? Ryoka grabbed a fry and bit into it. Zel did the same as he waited patiently.

"It's...complicated. If I told you, you might be in danger."

"Me?"

Zel looked amused by the notion.

"Miss Ryoka, I've been in danger since the first Antinium War. You might not know who I am—"

"Zel Shivertail. The Tidebreaker. I know."

He shrugged, looking embarrassed by the title. Zel reached for a handful of fries, chewing them down as he spoke.

“I’m not the best [General]. My reputation’s overinflated by stories, but I *am* a seasoned warrior. I’ve had [Assassins] and angry idiots after my head for over a decade. I think the Assassin’s Guild has given up trying to claim the price on my head. Even if an army were after me—or Ilvriss—”

“You’d still be in danger. I know who you are. And I’m still telling you that.”

Ryoka stared at Zel. He stopped chewing and looked at her.

“Really now?”

“Really really.”

“Huh.”

Zel’s tail flicked in interest. Behind him, Ryoka saw Ivolethe flying about, dragging something through the air as Mrsha chased and leapt after it. Both Frost Faerie and Gnoll were loving the game of tag.

“So it’s dangerous to us, hm? What about you? If you need protection —”

“Telling you would make things worse, believe me. I—look, I can’t tell you much. At all. But I call tell you this. *I* didn’t kill Periss. I didn’t do anything. I didn’t lure her into a trap on purpose or tell someone to kill her—she followed me and she died. I’m sorry it happened, but it was an accident on all sides.”

“In the forest. There was some kind of enchantment there that made me lose my way.”

Zel looked thoughtfully at Ryoka. She bit her lip.

“Don’t ask me anymore. And don’t go looking, please. For your sake. Just let it go.”

“I can let some things go. But my, uh, friend won’t. Ilvriss...that idiot won’t admit it, but I think he and Periss were a couple.”

Ryoka’s heart hurt as it sank.

“He—was?”

Zel nodded. He drummed his claws on the table, which made them cut into the wood until he noticed it and stopped.

“Damn. Sorry. Yes, well, it would be a scandal for a Wall Lord and a lowly officer in his army to be together, but I think that’s why he’s so obsessed. He loved her.”

“I’m sorry. But I still can’t tell you anything.”

Ryoka whispered the words. Zel looked at her. He stared at Ryoka in a way that made her think he was looking into her hidden heart. Then it was done and he nodded.

“I guess that’s all you can tell me for now. I’ll tell Ilvriss what you said, although I can’t promise he’ll stop coming after you. I can stop him, but perhaps...well, we’ll leave it at that for today. I know you’re busy, Ryoka. It was a pleasure to meet you again, regardless.”

He stood up, and pulled something out from a pocket. Ryoka blinked as she saw a dangling piece of metal shaped to look like a slow spiral. There was a large gem in the center, and evenly spaced smaller gems—diamonds perhaps—set along the curving bit of metal. Like a progression. Each one of the gems was glowing a different shade of green—some bright green, one a very pale green, almost yellow. But the biggest gem shone bright and green.

Zel inspected the gems critically for a second and then shook his head.

“Hm. You were telling the truth about all of that. Ilvriss might not be happy, but at least he won’t try to cut my tail off.”

“What—is that—”

“Oh, this is a truth detector. It’s a bit fancier than the truth gems—it records a number of statements so I don’t have to keep looking at it. It’s not very useful, considering you can do the same with a single gem, but Ilvriss insisted.”

“You—”

He put her through a lie detector test! Ryoka gaped at the [General]. He smiled wryly.

“Sorry, but I had to be certain.”

He pocketed the artifact and walked towards the entrance of the inn, smiling and speaking to Lyonette briefly while Ryoka sat in shock.

Truth gems. Ryoka closed her eyes briefly. *This* was why lying and keeping secrets was so much harder in this world! She really needed to buy something that would negate the effects of such spells. Was there such a thing?

“Hey Ryoka, are you okay? What did Zel want?”

The young woman opened her eyes. Erin hovered next to the table, looking concerned. She had a pair of full mugs in her hand and Ryoka eyed the alcohol with no little degree of temptation.

“What did he want? Uh—well, he was asking about a time when I met him, Erin.”

“You met Zel before? Really?”

“Yep. On my run. I met him and Ilvriss. It’s uh, complicated.”

“Wow.”

Erin looked impressed. She glanced towards the door, but Zel had already left. Still, she leaned down and whispered conspiratorially to Ryoka.

“He’s a pretty big deal among the Drakes. He’s some kind of war hero, and he’s really scary, in a grandfather-type way, you know?”

“I...guess?”

Ryoka couldn’t exactly see that. Then again, she’d met Zel when he was slicing people apart with his claws. Erin nodded.

“He’s cool, though. I uh, think he doesn’t like me as much, but he’s really nice to Lyonette and Mrsha!”

“Oh. Right. He stays here.”

“That’s right!”

So she’d be seeing him around. Ryoka’s heart sank. Erin eyed her friend, and put the mugs on the table.

“Is everything okay? Are you in a big trouble with that Ilvriss guy? Because if you are, I can talk to Zel—”

“No, I can sort it out. I think.”

Ryoka didn't want to get Erin involved. She knew a bit about the Necromancer—Ryoka had told her in a moment of idiocy. But she couldn't get Erin involved any more. Ryoka wasn't sure how dangerous telling people about Az'kerash was, yet. So she wouldn't tell Erin.

There was a pang in Ryoka's chest as she thought that. Wasn't the key problem in every stupid B-grade film keeping secrets? Only, there were some secrets that needed to be kept.

Even from friends? Ryoka cleared her throat and looked at Erin. Her friend. But how long had it been since they'd had a chance to talk? So much had happened...

"Hey Erin, I know we haven't gotten a chance to talk. I just wanted to say thanks..."

Erin waved a hand at her, looking awkward.

"Aw, don't mention it. I heard an angry Drake was chasing you around the city with a sword, so I called in a few favors. We should talk—"

"We should!"

Ryoka wanted to say more, but someone—an angry Stitch-girl waving a mug—called Erin's name and she had to rush off. Ryoka sank back into her seat. This wasn't how she'd envisioned coming back. All she wanted to do was talk to Erin for a bit, but now here came...

"Ksmvr?"

It was still hard for Ryoka to tell the Antinium apart, but Ksmvr's lack of a fourth arm helped in identifying him.

"Good evening Miss Ryoka Griffin. I am here to politely inquire about the magical items my party loaned you for the purposes of identification. I am not seeking this knowledge in an avaricious way; merely in order to assist and participate in my adventuring group's success."

Ryoka stared at him. She put her head in her hands. Ksmvr stared at her and then at her french fries.

"Are you eating that?"

“Dead gods.”

“Tree rot.”

“Silver and steel.”

“I lack an appropriate expression for this moment. Comrade Pisces, assist me with determining one.”

“I think, wow is probably all you need, Ksmvr.”

Jelaqua Ivirith spoke drily as she peered over the shoulder of Ceria. The other Horns of Hammerad were frozen as they stared at the pile of weapons, armor, and other magical artifacts Ryoka had taken from her bag of holding and piled on the table. The other Gold-rank adventurers in the room were watching from a respectable distance, pretending to eat. But they couldn’t take their eyes off the sparkling treasure any more than Erin could.

“Look at it all. There’s a pair of vambraces, swords—”

“A magical robe, a wand—no, *two* wands, and a *spellbook*—”

Ceria was gingerly touching the artifacts as if they might explode. She held up a spellbook, the color bright yellow and inscribed with the dark outline of some kind of bird in flight. Pisces picked up one of the rings and stared at a second sword with a frown.

“That wasn’t one of the items we recovered. Was it in the bag of holding?”

“Was *all* of this in the bag of holding?”

Ceria turned to Ryoka, wide-eyed. The Runner girl stood with her hands in her pockets, smiling awkwardly at the others’ dumbfounded expressions. Mrsha reached for the dagger and Lyonette grabbed her. Ivolethe did the same until Erin lured her away with a bowl full of raw meat and honey.

“There’s no way. Look at all these items! There’s equipment for me, Pisces, Yvlon—there’s equipment for everyone!”

“Amazing.”

Yvlon picked up the buckler and stared at the faint scar, the seam of metal almost invisibly merged together. She tapped the buckler and nearly dropped it when a transparent, shimmering field extended from the sides of the buckler, creating a second shield that overlapped the first, creating a magical barrier in the air.

“I note these swords are not reacting despite their apparent enchantments. May I hold both, or will I burst into flame and die in excruciating agony?”

Ksmvr stared at Ryoka. His words created a momentary hush before Ryoka recovered her tongue.

“It’s fine, Ksmvr.”

“Ah, the enchantments do not conflict?”

She shook her head.

“Some of it *is* lower-grade stuff, but it’s all compatible or so I’m told. That’s the real benefit here. An expert [Enchanter] did the matching up so you should be able to equip any combination of items without the enchantments clashing.”

“Dead gods.”

Ceria breathed the words out. Her hands were shaking. Erin could understand her emotions.

“I thought you could only use one or two artifacts or else they’d combine and explode!”

“Only if the enchantments are poorly woven. But if an expert in the field were to select quality pieces, an adventurer may wear a large variety of enchanted items.”

Typhenous remarked as he studied the ring Pisces had picked up with unconcealed envy. Ulrien nodded.

“That’s a service a lot of Gold-rank adventurers and Named Adventurers pay for. Your group is exceptionally lucky.”

“But how? I’m sure this all wasn’t in the bag of holding—”

Ceria turned to Ryoka, looking bewildered. Ryoka took a deep breath. This was the part she'd been worried about.

"I had to sell one of the items from the bag. It was valuable. Really valuable. The [Enchanter] I talked to agreed to exchange all of this for the item. He also says he owes you a favor you can call in at any time."

Everyone went silent at the news. Yvlon glanced at Ceria and Ksmvr scratched at one antennae. At last, Seborn broke the silence. He and Moore were staring at one of the rings Pisces was holding with a frown.

"It must have been some item."

"Indeed."

Pisces' eyes narrowed. He glanced at the array of magical items Hedault had found for Ryoka.

"The fact that you refuse to tell us is indication alone of its worth. Why not reveal its nature...unless you think you made a poor deal? Or perhaps one better than the quality of arms represented here?"

Ryoka frowned, feeling defensive and feeling that she shouldn't feel defensive. She turned towards Pisces as Ceria and Yvlon stared at her.

"I don't want to tell you because if I did, you might have gotten into a fight about it. It was an item two of you could use, and only one of you could have."

Ceria and Pisces traded glances, while Ksmvr and Yvlon stared at each other. The Horns of Hammerad looked at Ryoka. Pisces' tone was accusing.

"So one of us could have used it to great effect—"

"But only one of you. And it would have caused a huge fight, believe me."

"So you sold it without consulting us."

"Pisces!"

Ceria snapped at Pisces, who'd folded his arms disapprovingly.

"We agreed to let Ryoka decide what to do. If she says it was better to sell the artifact—"

“Again, without consulting us. She might have let us know what it was, first.”

“But then we’d fight, wouldn’t we?”

Yvlon frowned at Pisces. She stared at the items, thinking aloud.

“No matter what it was...I bet it would have caused issues, even if we decided whose it would be. How fair would it have been to split the loot afterwards? What if someone wanted to take it and abandon the team? I’ve seen groups torn apart over that before.”

Ceria nodded slowly, and Ksmvr stared at Ceria before nodding energetically as well. Pisces blew out his cheeks, looking annoyed, but someone else voiced their agreement.

“I’ve seen the same thing as well. It happens all the time and it can lead to bloodshed when people fight over the best artifact.”

Jelaqua crossed her arms as she sat at a table with Ulrien and Halrac. Both Gold-rank adventurers nodded as the Selphid spoke directly to Pisces.

“I think you’d better thank your Runner friend here, Horns of Hammerad. She might have spared you an ugly argument.”

Revi, Typhenous, Moore, and Seborn all murmured in agreement. Pisces looked around for support and found none. He sighed dramatically.

“Very well. I suppose I must withdraw my issue. But let us at least find out what we paid for.”

Ryoka smiled, feeling relieved and grateful towards the other adventurers.

“It’s worth it, believe me. Hedault—the guy who did all the appraising and buying—found some quality stuff for you.”

She began to list out the items from memory, handing each one around as the Horns of Hammerad clustered around the table. They were practically shaking with excitement, and the other adventurers drew close, taking the item after the others were done with it and looking it over and talking softly. Erin and Lyonette got a chance to investigate the artifacts too, although Mrsha was banned from touching, much to the Gnoll’s quiet grievance.

“The biggest items are the sword with the weight enchantment, the Flamecoat Dagger, the Forceshield Buckler, the [Barkskin] ring, the Ring of Jumping...and the ring that shoots the attack spell. There are a few potions and the bag of glowing stones and monster lure...”

Ryoka showed the Horns of Hammerad the ball with the angry face. Mrsha leapt up onto the table to touch it. It began *shrieking* and scared Mrsha so badly she fled into the kitchen, crying, until Lyonette went to cuddle her and pour a bit of healing potion into her sensitive ears.

“Ow. Okay, so that’s the stuff we recovered. What’s the rest of this?”

Ceria rubbed at her own ears. Ryoka smiled.

“Nothing too good according to Hedault, which means decent protective enchantments on all the gear. Yvlon—you’ve already got the chest plate, right. I have the vambraces and greaves for you...a helmet as well, and there’s gauntlets somewhere...”

“How strong are the enchantments?”

Erin remarked with interest as she peered at the plain steel gauntlets Yvlon was trying on. The woman winced as she struck part of the metal in her skin with the edge. Jelaqua struck the chest plate with the head of her flail experimentally and nodded in approval.

“This is good stuff. I’ve seen enchantments like these before. They cushion blows, not just make the metal stronger. Give me a good cuirass and I could kill a score of zombies by myself.”

“You could kill a group of Ghouls with that sword if you’re quick enough.”

Ulrien remarked as he tested the sword by tapping Moore’s staff as the half-Giant blocked. Moore grunted softly.

“A strong enchantment. Very nice.”

“You bet. And I’ve got a robe for Pisces. It only has a small protective charm, but I’m told it resists stains. And it’s white.”

“Thank the leaves for that.”

Pisces sniffed as Ceria tossed the robe at him. He was studying the two wands. There were also three rings sitting on the table next to them.

“Am I to understand these are both for us? What of the rings?”

Ryoka nodded, smiling.

“Two wands, both made of...damn, I forget. Some kind of redwood tree? Hedault said it didn’t really matter. The centers are filled with Waisrabbit bone in one, and Gazereye—the stone, not the actual eye of a Gazer—in the other.”

“Low-quality materials, but acceptable. I shall use the bone wand, Ceria, if you agree.”

“Fine by me.”

“Aw. Rabbit bone and stone? Is that really wand material?”

Erin peered dubiously at the wands. It was Pisces who answered with a second, self-important sniff.

“Both materials are decently rare and certainly useful as catalysts, Erin. Gazereye is a decently powerful hallucinogenic stone whose powers are magical and Waisrabbits have several unique abilities.”

“Like what?”

“They can teleport. And cast a form of offensive magic. They’re quite hard to catch. These wands would be costly, if not exactly hard to acquire. What of the rings, Ryoka?”

“Okay, there’s three of them...uh, I think this one has the [Lightweight] enchantment. I thought it would be good for Ksmvr and Yvlon—you won’t be slowed down by the armor.”

“That’s handy.”

“These two...Ksmvr, this ring lets you breathe underwater.”

Ksmvr paused.

“Very valuable. I shall take it.”

Ryoka sensed Ulrien and Halrac’s eyes on her. They knew that she knew the Antinium’s weak point. She cleared her throat and went on.

“And for you Ceria, I have this ring that has a catalyst built into it. It’s supposed to help amplify your ice spells. See, the outside is enchanted to insulate the inner part, because inside of it is—”

“Everfreeze Ice. I see.”

Pisces inspected the ring. Ryoka blinked.

“You can tell?”

“Oh yes. Springwalker could draw from the cold of the ice in situations where the temperature does not suit her spellcasting. It is a good choice. But where is my ring?”

“I have a spellbook. One filled with a few decent Tier 3 spells and some unusual Tier 2 and Tier 1 spells.”

Ryoka offered it to Pisces. He took it without comment and began flipping through it with desultory interest.

“And for me?”

Ksmvr stared at Ryoka. She smiled awkwardly.

“I didn’t know if any of the armor I got would fit you, Ksmvr. So instead I had Hedault find another sword. It’s enchanted to be a bit sharper and sturdier, but not much more. I’m told it’s good enough for a Gold-rank adventurer, though. I have a cloak designed to protect from mundane arrows as well, but that’s all I could find that would fit you. I got you a bow that can shoot twice as far and some enchanted arrows, but no armor. Sorry.”

The Antinium paused, and then nodded.

“That is quite enough. My thanks for the consideration you have shown.”

Ryoka paused. She had her hand over the bag of holding the Horns had given her. Now she reached into it and began to pull out potions, a scroll, a length of enchanted rope...

“This is extra stuff, but it’s the kind of adventuring gear that Gold-rank adventurers use. I’ve got strong healing potions, mana potions...enough to get you all set up.”

The Horns of Hammerad clustered around, appraising the items. Pisces looked quite impressed by the quality of the healing potions and tried to pocket one before Ceria caught him.

Revi edged over to her teammates. She whispered to them as the others kept talking.

“Hey Ulrien, Halrac, appraise how much those extra items were worth for me.”

The two experienced adventurers frowned. Ulrien started counting on his fingers.

“A full set of matching enchanted plate armor is...ten thousand gold pieces at least.”

“*That* much?”

“I don’t have a matching set of armor. Even if all the enchantments aren’t of the same quality, the fact that they don’t conflict is what matters. That’s why I use other enchantments and don’t wear plate at all. As for the wands, what do you think, Halrac?”

“At least a thousand gold pieces each. That [Necromancer] is underselling them. They’re not cheap, hundred gold-piece wands with an expendable spell. As for the sword...if it’s good enough for Gold-rank, it’s worth a few thousand gold.”

“Oh come on. I’ve seen weapons for a few hundred—”

“Not if it’s *good*, Revi. Quality matters and these ones have no mana bleed. That doubles their prices alone. Add in a spellbook for a thousand... robes are probably a few hundred...expensive cloak if it can resist arrow strikes...the bow...rings...”

“Don’t forget those potions and the other items. Some look useful.”

Halrac nodded.

“Say twenty five thousand for the lot?”

“*Twenty five thousand?*”

He shrugged.

“I’m guessing. It could be half again as much. Or half that if you have a haggling Skill. The fact that all the enchantments don’t spill over is incredibly useful. It means the Horns can upgrade their pieces without fear or swap them out. That’s worth a large amount. As for the rest...”

“Makes you wonder what the item they sold was. It must have been expensive.”

Ulrien frowned thoughtfully.

“The real question is how big the debt the [Enchanter] owes them is. Is it a small favor or...?”

They turned their attention back to Ceria as she spoke to the others, gesturing to Ksmvr.

“We have a decent spread of equipment—and *more* gold than we gave Ryoka. We can outfit Ksmvr with anything else he might need.”

Ceria pointed to the pile on the table as she turned to the others. She was shaking and grinning at the same time. She hesitated, opened her mouth, turned to the rest of her group.

“Should we...start dividing stuff up? Does anyone have a preference?”

“The robes, armor and so on are easily divided. However, the most powerful items—the dagger, sword, buckler, and three rings are not. I shall express my desire for the [Barkskin] ring and the ring that projects the spell immediately.”

Pisces picked up both rings, looking at the others. Ceria frowned.

“You can’t have two rings, Pisces.”

“Why not?”

“Because I want that ring.”

“Shouldn’t a warrior have it?”

“Yeah, but it’s [Barkskin]. Do you know how useful that is?”

“I do. That is why I want it.”

“Hold on, let’s not fight. We should decide who gets the easiest items to assign first.”

Yvlon interrupted the squabble between the two [Mages] as she picked up the sword. She swung it carefully as everyone backed up to let her do it. Yvlon looked at the sword, and then wistfully at the buckler.

“As much as I’d like a magical shield, having a sword like this has been a dream of mine. Ksmvr, would you let me take this one?”

“Yes, Comrade Yvlon. And I believe you should have this as well given that you are more proficient with it than I.”

To everyone’s surprise, Ksmvr handed the buckler to Yvlon. She tried to push it back, looking shocked.

“I can’t have both!”

“It is only logical. You are specialized in the sword and shield style of fighting, Comrade Yvlon. I am used to any number of weapon combinations. It would be most effective to concentrate strength in one member of the party.”

“But I—no, it wouldn’t be fair.”

“But it is I who insist. As a member of the party, I wish to make the most advantageous decision for the group possible.”

Everyone stared at Ksmvr. He shrugged. Yvlon looked moved to tears as she took the buckler.

“Call me Yvlon, Ksmvr. I’m sure I’ve told you that. And if you’re sure, I’ll gladly accept. But I won’t forget this.”

Ksmvr smiled, raising his mandibles and parting them slightly as Yvlon put the buckler on one arm and held the sword with the other. Fully armored once again and holding the two enchanted items, she looked like she was ready for another battle. Ryoka had to smile. Ksmvr’s generosity did unpleasantly happy things to her heart, and she saw Jelaqua nudge her two companions and grin as well. Halrac looked approving, and Ulrien and Typhenous were nodding in tandem.

Ashamed by Ksmvr’s display, Ceria and Pisces stopped fighting over the rings and looked at each other.

“Ksmvr’s right. You take the ring with the spell attack, Pisces.”

“And you take the [Barkskin] ring, Ceria.”

“No.”

To the surprise of all again, Ceria handed both the [Barkskin] ring and the Ring of Jumping to Ksmvr. He stared down at them.

“But if I accept these items, what will you have, Captain Ceria?”

“Call me Ceria too, Ksmvr. And I have the spellbook. I think it’s fair if I don’t take an item, right Pisces?”

She looked at the [Necromancer]. He looked startled, and then shook his head.

“One item would be appropriate, Ceria.”

“Not if Ksmvr needs it. Ryoka had the right idea with the cloak, but Ksmvr can’t wear armor like most of us. He needs protection. As for the ring...I’m not a frog, and I hate heights. I don’t think you want to leap around, Pisces, Yvlon—”

“No thanks.”

Ryoka bit her lip as Ksmvr accepted the ring. She really, *really* would have liked it for herself. But she didn’t want to say it out loud and spoil the mood.

Newly equipped, the Horns of Hammerad looked at each other. Pisces was smiling, and Yvlon looked like a girl with a bunch of toys. Sharp, deadly toys.

“What do we do now, oh Captain? I want to run out and challenge a Mothbear right now.”

Ceria nodded, flipping the wand over in her hands and catching it. With a pang, Ryoka realized she alone would have only two new items from all of this, the wand and ring. But Ceria seemed happy enough. She thought, and then indicated the wand in her hands.

“Practice first. We have to know how to fight with all this—this equipment! Then we’ll think about what we could do with our new gear. I’ll bet there are all sorts of new tactics we could employ...”

“You might also want to see if the Guild will recertify you as Gold-rank adventurers.”

Everyone looked at Ulrien. The big man pointed at Yvlon’s sword.

“Your gear alone could make you a Gold-rank, Miss Yvlon. And given the experience of the others and your ability, I’d say getting the Guild to confirm your rank might be easy. If not, one or two requests would certainly put you there.”

“Gold rank.”

Ceria and Yvlon breathed the words. Ryoka held her breath. Just like that. The Horns of Hammerad had approached the next tier of adventuring in a single moment. The moment lasted right up until Typhenous coughed.

“On the note of artifacts, I hate to make the request now, but before you are too accustomed to your items, I would like to ask if you had considered selling the ring young Pisces holds.”

The Horns of Hammerad stared at Typhenous. Ulrien nudged the older mage, looking disapproving, but Typhenous wouldn’t be dissuaded.

“I will pay more than the ring’s worth, enough for another magical item of similar or equal value. Such a ring could be quite useful to me.”

“Hey, if you’re bidding, what about me? I’ll pay more than Typhenous. Just show me what it can do.”

Revi crowded over to Pisces. Erin waved her hands frantically.

“Not indoors!”

Seborn stared at the table.

“If we’re bidding, I’d like to ask if you’d consider selling the dagger. No one claimed that.”

“Oh, right! No one here uses daggers. I mean, have a backup, but I don’t need one. And Ksmvr—”

Ceria wavered. She looked at Ksmvr, who shrugged.

“I could use the weapon, but if it will assist the group as a whole...”

“How much would you pay for the dagger?”

Pisces’ eyes gleamed. Seborn began to count on his fingers. Typhenous and Revi were arguing and Ulrien was arguing with the both of them. Ceria raised her hands and shouted.

“Please, not right now! We won’t sell anything until we discuss...”

She looked helplessly at the others. Ulrien nodded.

“Ease off them, Typhenous, Revi. They’ve just gotten their first big haul. You remember how overwhelming that moment is.”

“Ah, I do. To be young again.”

Typhenous sighed, looking only slightly disappointed. Then he clicked his fingers together and created a shower of sparks in every color that delighted Mrsha.

“This calls for a celebration, doesn’t it?”

“Of course!”

Jelaqua sprang onto a table with a mug. Mrsha leapt up beside her and the Selphid laughed and raised a mug towards Ceria and the others.

“To the Horns of Hammerad, on getting their first true haul from a dungeon! Erin, roll out some more kegs! It’s time to celebrate this properly!”

Everyone in the room cheered. Ceria laughed and Erin had to smile as Lyonette ran over to the bar’s counter to count how many kegs they actually had and if she’d have to buy more from Krshia.

“Party!”

Ryoka stared around as Yvlon and Ceria hugged each other and Jelaqua laughed and quaffed until Moore lifted her off the table. At once, the mood in the inn had turned festive. The Runner heard Halrac as the [Scout] turned to Revi.

“You’re not going to complain about another party, are you?”

Revi sniffed.

“What do you take me for? I’m all for having *fun*. Hey Erin, just *leave* the keg out here why don’t you?”

“Hey, that’s the best idea you’ve ever had, Revi!”

Erin disappeared into the kitchen and then came out and helped Ulrien lift a barrel onto a table. Moore picked up another one and put it on a second table, and then Ryoka had a mug in her hands. Ceria hugged her.

“You did it. We have to thank you—and talk about paying you later!”

“Oh, that’s really not—”

Ryoka didn’t get a chance to finish. Suddenly Ceria was yelling for everyone to toast her. And of course, a toast meant a long drink. And Ryoka *was* tired from the road, and then Ivolethe decided to make off with a mug meant for Moore...

That was how the party went. Ryoka found herself playing with the bag of glowing stones, rolling them as Mrsha ran excitedly after the glowing treasures. Somehow, the people in the city had heard about the party—perhaps it was a Skill, or maybe there was a class, [Partycrasher]—and she saw familiar and unfamiliar faces mixing and laughing.

Then the door to Celum opened. Ryoka’s jaw dropped as a familiar head poked through. Octavia blinked as the wave of sound and light hit her.

“What the *fuck*?”

No one had told her about the door. Ryoka’s jaw stayed open as Octavia opened the door wider, exposing her shop, and then walked through, straight from Celum to Liscor in a moment. She raised her voice, called out.

“Hey Erin, I have another question about—is that *Ryoka*?”

She caught sight of Ryoka and nearly ran straight over Lyonette. The [Princess] turned [Barmaid] had a tray of drinks and slopped some onto Octavia’s front.

“Sorry, sorry! Uh, want a drink?”

“Don’t mind if I do!”

Octavia promptly forgot about what she wanted Erin for, took the mug, and laughed as she came over to Ryoka.

“Ryoka! You didn’t tell me you were in Liscor!”

“How did you—”

“Oh, the door? Wonderful thing. I still think I should be charging a fee, what with Erin putting it in my shop. You didn’t know? Well, it’s not like you ran all the way to Liscor from Celum, is it? Hah! Runner joke there. Don’t scowl. Uh...so anyways, there’s this door. Let me tell you all about it!”

It was a garbled explanation, but Ryoka got the gist. After Octavia had wandered away to find a second drink—she'd downed the first one with incredible speed—Ryoka went looking for Erin. She had a *magical door*? Ryoka's mind felt stretched by the possibilities it represented.

“Hey Erin. About this door—”

“Oh, right! The door! Yeah, didn't I tell you about it? It's amazing—”

“If you did, I don't remember!”

“*What?*”

“I said if you did—”

“Sorry, let me—Lyonette! I have the noodles ready! Where'd you put the beef?”

Turning her head, Ryoka saw Lyonette scream back across the room.

“Upper left pantry!”

“Thanks!”

Erin went to the upper left pantry, and Ryoka saw to her horror that a plate of raw beef, still bloody and raw, was sitting there. She grabbed Erin's arm when the girl went to grab it.

“You're not going to cook that!”

“Yeah, why not?”

The girl stared at Ryoka blankly as Ryoka gabbled for words.

“It's *raw*! It's been sitting out there for...who knows how long! Haven't you frozen it or—or—”

“Oh! I get it!”

Erin slapped her forehead, grinning hugely.

“I have a new Skill!”

“What?”

“I just got it and—hang on, I'm coming!”

Erin turned and shouted at Ceria, who was waving and shouting something about a french fry disaster and Ksmvr. She made a face.

“Sorry! Explain in a bit.”

But it turned out that little bit was a while, and when Erin came back, she had to hurry and get the rest of the food she’d been cooking ready for the hungry partyers.

“So Erin, we should talk—”

“Totally! Totally! Hand me that bowl of butter, will you?”

Ryoka did. Erin grabbed it and put a generous dollop into her pasta, making it sinfully buttery. Ryoka had to raise her voice to make herself heard above the general din.

She’d followed Erin into the kitchen, but Ryoka had to keep stepping aside to let Lyonette and Erin rush about with dishes. Ryoka fed bits of marinated beef to Mrsha as she tried to keep up a conversation with Erin.

“So what’s been happening?”

“Oh...you know, stuff. Nothing much.”

That was a total non-answer and a lie, but really, what was Erin supposed to say? The [Innkeeper] was in her element, which was to say, doing everything at once for everyone. Ryoka saw Erin find a bowl for her beef, which was excellent, it had to be said, bring a pot of pasta out for people as Lyonette cleared a table, rush back into the kitchen to find plates, forks, knives, spoons...she was so busy and yet she turned Ryoka down when the girl offered to help.

“You have fun! You just got back, so...relax!”

Ryoka tried to, but she couldn’t help but feel guilty. Because she’d intended to talk with Erin, and she didn’t seem to have the opportunity to. She kept telling herself she’d do it later, when everything was quieter.

In her defense, it had been a long time since Ryoka had last been to the Wandering Inn.

How does news of a party spread? It could only be magical, or so Erin felt. It was some divine providence, some kind of fate that snagged people up and told the little part of their brains that lived for trying to limbo underneath a sword while drinking shots of Thunderhammer—it was close enough to what Erin had explained, so she let it go—that there was fun to be had.

Maybe that was how a group of Humans from Celum ended up mixing with the Gnolls and Drakes from Liscor. Then again, most were adventurers, and perhaps it was one of the Gold-rank adventurers who'd spread the word. They'd come to celebrate the Horns of Hammerad ostensibly; really, adventurers would use any excuse to eat and get drunk.

But they weren't the only ones. In the middle of the party, as Erin was debating having a seat and seeing if Ryoka had time to have a shouted conversation...maybe outside, she heard someone shout.

“Ryoka!”

Suddenly, the door to Celum was open and Garia and Fals came through. They made a beeline for Ryoka, who looked startled and pleased to see them. Erin smiled, but the smile slipped a bit and she had to hang onto it.

She was so *busy*. Erin hadn't been planning a party tonight and she had to scramble to use all the food in her stores. But it was a party for Ryoka and the Horns of Hammerad, so she worked hard and tried to make everyone happy, mainly by stuffing their faces and serving them drinks until they threw up, which was another problem. Erin kept busy into the night, serving tables, cooking more food. She was making money, and that was good too, right?

She was tired, dragging again, when it was over, sometime past midnight. Erin stared around the room, ready to crash despite the dirty tables, when she realized Ryoka didn't have anywhere to sleep.

“What if she sleeps upstairs with Mrsha and me? There's plenty of room.”

Lyonette suggested to the two as Erin wrung her hands and Ryoka offered to sleep in the basement. Erin nodded, relieved. Ryoka paused, looking and feeling guilty.

“Ah, well, it’s too late to chat. We have to catch up sometime, right?”

Erin smiled, tired, sleepy, a tiny bit upset. She glanced around the dirty inn, filled with things to do and lied to Ryoka.

“Oh, it’s no problem. We’ll talk tomorrow, right?”

“Yeah.”

Ryoka hesitated and then turned away, practically dead on her feet. Erin stared at a table, and knew if she didn’t clean up now, she’d have to do it while making breakfast. She lurched over to a table, wandering to sleep. Ryoka watched her friend, full of unsaid words and things she wanted to say or ask, but was too afraid to.

Two young women, two friends, stood in the dark inn by the flickering fire, feeling more like strangers because they hadn’t talked yet. Because they had their own lives, which was natural. But they still felt the distance.

And then as Ryoka got ready to sleep in a room where a small Gnoll cub was lying on the floor in the moonlight, her sides rising and falling, Lyonette drew Ryoka aside. She told her about Christmas. And Ryoka remembered the sight of Erin bending over a table, collecting dishes in the darkness, and knew what she had to do.

4.11

Ryoka woke up when she stopped breathing. It wasn't that she'd stopped trying of course; it was just that trying to inhale through a layer of fur was a nearly impossible feat.

“Grfph!”

Mrsha had been happily sleeping in her new spot on Ryoka's head. She went flying as Ryoka sat up, but landed in her actual bed. She woke up, looked around, and glared at Ryoka reproachfully.

Ryoka glared back. She coughed, spat out a bit of white fur, and looked around.

“That was not fun. Mrsha, you're not a cat. Don't act like one.”

The Gnoll sat up and yawned. She scratched at her head with a paw, and then padded over to Ryoka. She began to rub her head against Ryoka's face.

That was like a cat. But a cat didn't hug you. Ryoka felt her irritation slipping away. She hesitated, then hugged Mrsha back.

“Okay. Okay, I guess I can forgive you. Why don't we have breakfast now that I'm up?”

The Gnoll nodded eagerly. She scampered towards the stairs and Ryoka wondered what she was going to do with Mrsha. What could she do? The Gnoll was homeless. This was a good home for her, but—

She wasn't a cat. She was a person, a child. Yet she couldn't speak. And Ryoka had no idea how old Mrsha really was. Urksh had talked to her like she was a kid, but she could be anywhere from just a baby to a pre-teen by that standard.

Ryoka dressed herself and blinked at the dark sky. She walked downstairs, hearing Mrsha running about. Her mind was filled with somber thoughts.

If she was in her tribe, Mrsha might have grown up fine. She could be a [Hunter], a [Cook]—her disability wouldn't hinder anything else. But if she

grew up here, what would she do when she was older? Get a job at Erin's inn?

Would they be around that long? Would Erin and Ryoka grow up here? Really? And if they didn't, what would happen to Mrsha, to Lyonette, when they left?

These were dark thoughts for a morning. Ryoka decided she wanted to face them on a full stomach. Hopefully Erin was awake. Maybe Ryoka could sneak by her and steal some food? The Asian girl blinked as she entered the common room of the inn.

"Huh."

"Morning, Ryoka! Want some honey bread and sausage?"

Erin grinned as she turned with frying pan and spatula in hand. She finished ladling hot, sizzling sausage onto Zel Shivertail's plate as Mrsha sat herself down next to him. The Gnoll cub waved to Ryoka and bounced up and down in her seat.

"Erin. You're already up?"

"Yup! I've been awake for like an hour. Or two? Lyonette's got your bread. Hey Mrsha, leave some honey for Ryoka, okay?"

The Gnoll nodded eagerly as Lyonette emerged from the kitchen with some bread, steaming, freshly cut. Ryoka's stomach began to rumble the instant she smelled it.

"Good morning, Ryoka."

Zel greeted Ryoka as if there was nothing odd about sitting with Mrsha. He smiled as Mrsha reached for a mug in Lyonette's hand. The [Princess] frowned at Mrsha.

"Don't grab or I'll drop everything, Mrsha."

Obediently, Mrsha sat and waited for Lyonette to put the mug on the table. Lyon turned and smiled at Ryoka.

"Hi Ryoka. Is bread and sausage good?"

"Uh...sure."

Still blinking sleep from her eyes, Ryoka sat at the table across from Zel. She watched as Mrsha began to slurp greedily at the warm honeyed milk. In moments, she had her own plate of bread, sausage, and a mug of hot milk. Zel passed a bowl of honey across the table and Ryoka slathered it over her bread.

“Hell of a breakfast.”

“I’m growing soft with age. I can’t stay here too long or I’ll get spoiled by the food.”

Zel sighed happily as he patted his stomach. He eyed Ryoka, and the young woman tensed slightly. But Zel just nodded to the honey.

“Mind passing it back? I think Mrsha wants more.”

That was breakfast. Zel didn’t speak much, and Mrsha was happy enough to provide enough entertainment at the table. She unabashedly tried to steal food from both Ryoka and Zel’s plates when she was done with her food. Not because she was hungry; Ryoka was sure she could get more if she wanted. It seemed to be a game.

Zel casually blocked Mrsha’s paws, smiling fondly as she tried to sneak around his plate and grab his food. Ryoka deliberately lifted her plate up as Mrsha tried the same on her; the Gnoll leapt onto her chair and tried to climb Ryoka’s head.

“Mrsha!”

Lyonette rescued Ryoka as Ryoka tried to keep from dropping her plate. She pulled Mrsha off and made the Gnoll apologize to Ryoka. Then more people came downstairs, attracted by the noise and food. And then a door opened and the Horns of Hammerad came *up* out of the basement.

“Ah, is Mrsha causing trouble again?”

Ceria smiled at the Gnoll. Pisces blinked and rubbed at his face as he slumped over to a table. He didn’t seem to wake up until Lyonette passed him a mug and put food in front of his face.

“Don’t try stealing from me today, child.”

Revi stared at Mrsha as the Gnoll abandoned her table in search of new targets. She tugged at a loose thread around her neck as Mrsha ignored her.

Jelaqua laughed as she tempted Mrsha over with a sausage held in pallid fingers. Mrsha leapt, but Jelaqua's hand blurred and she was chomping down the sausage and catching Mrsha by the time the Gnoll landed.

"Please don't encourage her, Jelaqua."

Ryoka stared as the room filled with adventurers. She blinked down at her empty mug and raised it as Lyonette passed by with a pitcher.

"Oops. Here you are, Ryoka."

Ryoka sipped at the sweet honey milk and then turned her head as a door opened. Not to the front of the inn. Rather, a door set in the side of the wall opened and closed. Ryoka stared as Octavia, looking more disheveled than Pisces, stumbled in.

"Food? Food..."

She stumbled over to a table and put her head down. She was red-eyed and had shadows from lack of sleep. She ate her bread like a starving thing, scarfing it down and snarled at Mrsha when the Gnoll got close.

This was how breakfast in Erin's inn went. Ryoka sat, sipping her drink with Zel as she watched Pisces tease Mrsha, levitating a chunk of honey-coated bread just over the Gnoll's head as she leapt and tried to catch it.

Ryoka saw how bustling Erin's inn was. She felt almost out of place in this new atmosphere, but she could see how it attracted people. There was good food to eat—bread not a minute out of the oven and hot sausage was a treat, even for someone who used to eat in fancy hotels and restaurants when her family travelled.

Ryoka watched as Lyonette rushed about the room, refilling drinks, taking requests, and because she knew to look for it, she watched Erin. The [Innkeeper] didn't stop moving. She was in the kitchen, cooking, chatting with Halrac at a table, breaking up a fight between Octavia and Pisces over the last piece of bread—and she'd been up for two hours already.

"Erin, I would love to talk about those magical dishes you made for those adventurers a day ago."

Jelaqua was speaking with Erin as the girl brought over a second loaf of bread to the table for Moore. Ryoka took a breath and stood up. Time to make her move.

“Excuse me?”

The adventurer and Erin looked over as Ryoka made her way over to them. Erin smiled, and Ryoka nodded politely at Jelaqua. She had a hard time not staring at the Selphid’s incredibly pale face, and a harder time not ogling the gigantic man sitting on the ground and still bending over the table, or the half-crustacean fellow.

“What’s up, Ryoka?”

“Sorry—Jelaqua, is it? I’m going to have to ask that you talk to Erin later. She’s got a prior appointment today.”

“Oh?”

Jelaqua’s eyebrows rose. She glanced at Erin, whose face had gone totally blank. Ryoka was just glad she didn’t need Erin to pretend anything. The girl was *awful* at lying.

“I do? Uh, I don’t remember Ryoka—”

“We’re going out. Just you and me.”

“What? We are?”

Every head in the room turned. Ryoka felt herself go a bit red. She still hated being at the center of attention. But she was getting used to it.

“That’s right. You need a break. And we’ve got catching up to do. So you can finish serving breakfast—”

“I can do it!”

Lyonette waved a hand eagerly. She winked unsubtly at Ryoka. Erin hesitated.

“But I should do lunch. And there’s this thing I do with adventurers, Ryoka—”

“Nope. It can wait. You go have fun!”

Jelaqua laughed. She reached out and slapped Erin on the back. The girl staggered a few steps until Ryoka caught her. Seborn kicked Jelaqua. The Selphid looked abashed.

“Oops. Sorry.”

“No problem. But I’ve got an inn, Ryoka. I can’t just—”

“No arguments. We’re going to go to Celum. Lyonette’s got the shop.”

“Hold on!”

Ceria called out, frowning. She looked at Ryoka.

“We wanted to talk with you, Ryoka. We still need to pay you for going all the way to Invril and getting all the artifacts appraised—”

“Tomorrow.”

Ryoka tried to drag Erin towards the door Octavia had stepped through. Someone else called out.

“Hold up! What about lunch?”

Revi crossed her arms. Ryoka stared at her.

“Get it somewhere else. Or I’m sure Lyonette could make something.”

“You’re just going to walk off with our [Innkeeper]? What if we need her?”

“Too bad. She needs a break.”

“Ryoka, really, I appreciate it, but—”

“Nope.”

There was an art to being a jerk. Ryoka shut Erin down and turned her. She began to push her towards the magical door. She met Zel’s eyes as the [General] stared at her in amusement and looked away. She aimed her next comment at the entire room.

“Erin needs a break and I want to catch up with her. But I can’t do that when every two seconds someone wants a piece of her, or needs her to solve some incredible problem.”

The adventurers in the room glanced at each other. Halrac nodded to Ulrien and the big adventurer spoke for his group.

“No objections. Go ahead, Miss Erin. You do deserve a break.”

“I—well—okay—but are you sure, Lyonette?”

“Go ahead!”

Mrsha ran after Erin and Ryoka, but that was fine. Ryoka had nearly gotten the weakly protesting Erin to the door.

“Maybe I can just help tidy up—”

“Nope. Now, let’s get out of here before—”

The door burst open. Ryoka heard a shout.

“Erin! *Erin!*”

Olesm ran into the room, trailing snow and looking about excitedly. He spotted Erin and made a beeline to her. Ryoka tried to bar the Drake as he danced excitedly around her and Erin.

“Erin, you’ll never guess what!”

“What?”

“I just got the most incredible communication from one of the Walled Cities. I just learned—and you’ll never believe this—”

“*Nope!*”

Ryoka threw her arms up and blocked Olesm as the Drake tried to show a letter to Erin. Olesm halted and stared at her, confused.

“Oh. Miss Ryoka. You’re back. Well, listen to this—”

“No.”

The [Tactician] looked surprised.

“No?”

“No. I’m sorry Olesm, but whatever you have to say, you’ll have to say it to Erin later. Tonight, maybe.”

“What? But I can’t wait that long—”

“Too bad. Erin’s busy. She’s taking a break today.”

Olesm stared at Ryoka, completely dumbfounded. He raised the scrap of parchment in his claws helplessly and gestured towards it.

“But it’s the most *incredible* news—”

“Is someone going to die if Erin doesn’t hear it?”

Ryoka crossed her arms. Olesm hesitated. His energetically waving tail slowed.

“...No.”

Ryoka nodded.

“In that case, will this incredible thing still be there tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

“Then it can wait. Erin, come on.”

“Sorry, Olesm.”

“Aw, but—”

Ryoka opened the door as Olesm danced in place, looking upset. He called out as Ryoka stared into Octavia’s shop, eying the place where Erin’s inn vanished and Octavia’s shop began. That was *real* magic.

“You first, Erin.”

“Okay.”

“But it would just take five minutes! Ten! Please?”

“No.”

“It’s about chess!”

“Don’t care.”

Erin’s head turned as Ryoka tried to push her through the door.

“Well, if it’s about *chess*—”

“No. You’re taking a break.”

Ryoka got her friend through the doorway. The people in Erin’s inn heard her arguing with the other girl for a moment, and then the door closed. Olesm stood dejectedly in the center of the inn, looking heartbroken.

A few seconds later, the door opened. Every head turned as Pawn walked into the inn, brushing snow off of his head. He was followed a second later by another Antinium holding a bow and a dead bird. Well,

‘bird’ was stretching the term generously. This one looked like a smaller version of a pterodactyl.

Pawn glanced around the room as Bird brushed snow off of his shoulders. He opened his mandibles and addressed Lyonette.

“Is Erin here?”

Bird raised his catch.

“I have birds. They are not rotten.”

Everyone stared at them. Ceria paused mid-chew and swallowed what was in her mouth. She looked at Yvlon, who smiled crookedly.

“Ryoka does have a point.”

“Aw, come on Ryoka. I want to know what Olesm has to say!”

“And you can. Later. For now—come on Mrsha. Don’t wander off!”

Ryoka strode down the street, shepherding Mrsha and Erin both. They were like cats. Mrsha hadn’t been part of Ryoka’s plan, but she’d snuck through the door into Celum behind the girls and Ryoka didn’t want to spend time trying to make her go back.

She had to talk with Erin. She had to. She’d put it off for too long. And she needed privacy to do that. So Ryoka took Erin to the one place where she was sure no one would bother them.

The Runner’s Guild in Celum.

Heads turned as Ryoka pushed open the door. She grinned as she walked into the room.

“Hey there. I’m back. Anyone miss me?”

For a second, Ryoka thought the [Receptionist] at the counter might have had a heart attack on seeing Ryoka’s face. Every eye immediately scanned Ryoka, searching no doubt for a small blue faerie. But Ryoka

hadn't spotted Ivolethe today. Instead, the Runners and [Receptionists] only saw Erin and Mrsha, sniffing the air curiously.

"Miss Ryoka, ah, how can we help you today?"

One of the female [Receptionists] hurried across the room towards Ryoka. She looked apprehensive, but Ryoka only smiled.

"I'd like to use one of the private meeting rooms if they're available. Can you give me a key?"

"A private—oh."

The [Receptionist] blinked at Erin. The other girl smiled at her.

"Hi, I'm Erin. How are you?"

Ryoka coughed.

"She's my client."

"Oh. *Oh*. In that case, let me just—"

The [Receptionist] hurried back to the counter and had a conversation with her co-worker. Erin edged over to Ryoka as Mrsha stared at the Runners and they stared back.

"Ryoka, what are we doing?"

"Finding somewhere quiet to talk."

The Runner's Guild was hardly a quiet place. However, it did have one feature that made it ideal for people who needed privacy, and that was the rule about Runner's confidentiality.

Whether it was a letter, a parcel, a giant flaming sword with the owner's name on it or anything in between, a Runner was supposed to keep the name of their clients and the nature of their delivery secret, even from people like [Guardsmen]. Unless they were testifying in relation to a crime, that was.

It was an unspoken code of conduct that wasn't as highly enforced among Street Runners, but City Runners and especially Couriers traded on their trustworthiness. Your reputation for keeping secrets was part of your identity as a Runner. A Runner who blabbed might find themselves out of work or with a knife in their back.

And to facilitate that need for secrecy, each Guild had one or two or many rooms that could be used by clients wanting to talk to Runners about personal deliveries. Such deals were often quite lucrative, and usually only occurred between Runners who'd worked with the same person for a number of years. They met in these rooms, which were shielded against eavesdropping and of course, completely private for the two to meet in safety.

This was what Ryoka wanted now. She waited until the woman at the desk came back with something in her hand. A key.

"Miss Ryoka, your room is the first up the stairs. I hope you and your client have a pleasant negotiation."

She stared at Erin, and the girl smiled at her. Ryoka smiled.

"Thanks. I notice you got all that snow cleared up. I guess I'm forgiven since you haven't kicked me out yet, right? Or is Persua banned for life?"

A muscle twitched in the [Receptionist]'s face.

"I believe the [Guildmaster] will want to speak with you later. But please, take this key."

She handed the key to Ryoka and turned away. Ryoka felt a bit guilty, but she still hadn't quite forgiven the Guild for letting Persua act like... Persua. Erin nudged Ryoka.

"What snow?"

"Oh—I'll explain in a bit. We're just going up the stairs to somewhere we can talk."

They made it halfway across the room when someone called out.

"Is that you, Ryoka?"

Ryoka groaned. But she turned and smiled as Garia Strongheart came over, smiling cautiously.

"Hey Garia."

"Hey Ryoka! I didn't think I'd see you here today. We only got to talk a bit last night...hi Erin. Who's this?"

She looked down at Mrsha. The Gnoll stared up at the bigger girl, circling her warily. Ryoka hesitated. That part of her that had recently appeared, the part that said she should be nice to Garia, was struggling with her blunt, rude self, which was to say, the rest of her.

“Sorry Garia, I’d love to chat, but I’ve really got to talk with Erin about something important. But uh...this is Mrsha.”

“Oh. Hello!”

Garia smiled at the Gnoll and reached down to scratch her ears like a dog. Mrsha recoiled and Garia paused. She looked a bit hurt on both counts, so Ryoka put a hand on her shoulder and smiled apologetically.

“If you’re still in the city after this, I’ll find you, okay?”

“Oh, it’s no problem. I wasn’t going to do a run today—I sort of sprained my ankle and I’m taking it easy. I had a healing potion, but it was low-quality...but I don’t want to get in the way of your conversation.”

Garia was so apologetic that it made Ryoka feel guilty. She ushered Erin up the stairs and into the first room she came to.

The room used for private meetings was filled with a nice table, padded chairs, and not much else. It had a window looking out into the city, but since they weren’t glass windows, the shutters were closed. Ryoka wondered what the rooms in the Runner’s Guild in Invril would have looked like.

“Okay, now we’re here.”

Erin blinked around the room as Mrsha leapt onto a chair and then onto the table. She took a seat while Ryoka hesitated and then took the one opposite her. It didn’t feel as comfortable as Ryoka had hoped—the room was meant for business deals, not chats.

“Sorry about all that. But I think we can talk here without anyone bothering us. No one’s allowed to disturb a private meeting unless there’s a real emergency.”

“Oh. So that’s why we’re here. We could have just talked at my inn. Come here, Mrsha.”

Erin let the Gnoll jump into her lap and cuddled her as she looked at Ryoka. The Runner coughed.

They were here. Ryoka had planned this out last night before she'd slept with Lyonette. It was a chance to talk to Erin, finally, with no one to interrupt.

Only now she was here, Ryoka realized she had no idea how to start. They were going to talk.

...How?

She couldn't think of how to start the conversation. Ryoka froze up. She felt as tongue-tied as she used to be. Erin was her friend. But she hadn't talked to her in...forever. How could she begin?

Erin wasn't helping. The girl was glancing around the room and whispering to Mrsha as the Gnoll wriggled happily in her arms. Ryoka felt the awkwardness quotient in the room rise until Erin broke the silence.

"Why did you say I needed a break, anyways?"

Ryoka stared at Mrsha as the Gnoll tried to carve into the wooden table with her claws. What was she supposed to say? No. She had to be honest.

"Lyonette told me about your Christmas party."

Erin paused. She looked down at her hands.

"Oh."

"Yeah."

Silence. It was the thing Ryoka dreaded the most. She looked at Erin, but she had no idea what the other girl was thinking. How could anyone read minds? Was she angry at Lyonette? Or Ryoka? Did she not want to talk about it?

Conversation was a quagmire, a bog of uncertainty. And Ryoka sank like a stone.

"I uh, well, it must have been rough."

Mrsha looked up as she sat in Erin's lap. Erin wasn't smiling. She stared at the shuttered window.

"Yeah. It was really embarrassing, to tell the truth."

Ryoka cleared her throat.

“Well, you must have been really stressed out.”

“I was.”

“It wasn’t your fault.”

“That’s nice of you to say. But y’know, it kinda was, right?”

“Well...”

Ryoka coughed and fidgeted. She cast about, tried another line.

“You have so much to do every day. I saw breakfast. That’s an undertaking.”

Erin nodded.

“Yeah. I don’t know how I could keep up without Lyonette’s help. She works really hard. I bet that was a surprise when you met her again, right?”

“I barely recognized her, to be honest.”

It was like meeting a completely different person. Ryoka could barely remember the previous Lyonette, when she’d met her again. The old one had been haughty, arrogant, and rude. This new Lyonette had callused hands, was always busy, and cared for Mrsha like a sister. Or a mother.

“What happened?”

“I left her alone. She was the only one in the inn and...”

Erin stared at the table. Then she looked at Ryoka, guiltily.

“I think she was starving. I mean, literally starving to death while I was gone. No one went to visit her except Olesm, and he only did it when he was checking if I’d come back. She must have...run out of food for a while. She didn’t say, but I think that’s what happened.”

“Jeez.”

Ryoka stared at the table blankly for a second. She didn’t know what she was supposed to say.

“That’s rough.”

Wholly inadequate words, delivered too late. Erin nodded. She stared at Ryoka, and Ryoka stared back until things got too awkward and they both looked away. Someone's stomach rumbled. To Ryoka's surprise, it wasn't Mrsha's.

"Sorry, that was me."

Erin patted Mrsha as the Gnoll turned to inspect her belly. She looked at Ryoka with a guilty grin.

"I know we're talking and stuff, but do you mind if we got something to eat? I actually uh, didn't have breakfast yet. I had some sausage and a bit of bread, but I was going to eat after everyone else..."

"Oh. Damn. Sorry—I'll check."

Flustered, Ryoka got up. She exited the door as Erin tried to stop Mrsha from ducking her head under her shirt. The [Receptionist] at the desk blinked as Ryoka strode over to her.

"Can I help you, Miss Ryoka?"

"Yes you can. Get us, uh—something to eat. We need snacks."

"Snacks?"

Ryoka nodded distractedly.

"A cheese platter or something."

"Ryoka?"

Someone called her name and came over. She turned and saw Fals grinning at her.

"Fancy meeting you here! Garia said you were in a meeting with Erin. Everything okay?"

"Fals. Good to see you."

Ryoka clasped his hand and then looked at the receptionist.

"Can we get something to eat?"

The woman hesitated, looking torn. It was customary for Runners to make these kinds of demands. Well, not *customary*, but if a Runner—or more likely, Courier—were meeting with an important client, refreshments

were a natural part of the negotiations. Only Ryoka thought that the [Receptionist] had clued into the fact that Erin and Mrsha weren't exactly VIP guests.

"Eat?"

Fals blinked at Ryoka, and then caught on. He winked at her while the [Receptionist] was looking away from him. Then he looked very concerned and raised his voice slightly.

"Oh, you mean for Miss Solstice? A *very* important guest. You're entertaining her here? I'm sure the Guild could get some of those jam buns down the street as well. After all, Erin does talk with Gold-rank adventurers on a daily basis."

"Not to mention a Drake [General]."

Ryoka saw the [Receptionist]'s eyes go round as she and Fals nodded at each other seriously. He had an excellent deadpan face.

Erin was teaching Mrsha how to do trust falls off of a chair and the Gnoll was doing absolutely no trusting or falling when Ryoka opened the door. Both looked up as Ryoka smiled hesitantly at them.

"Okay, there will be snacks sent up shortly. We'll also get drinks—I said you'd like fruit juice so they'll see what they have. Uh, I think we might get some buns, a cheese platter—what?"

Her friend was giving her an amused look.

"That's a lot of food! I could have just eaten an apple, you know."

"Uh, sorry."

Ryoka flushed a bit.

"I just wanted to get everything we might want right away. There will be uh, pillows delivered as well."

Erin burst out laughing and Ryoka felt herself go crimson. But before embarrassment could poke her with hot needles, Erin was nodding

appreciatively.

“I totally support your decision, Ryoka. One hundred and twelve percent. I did the exact same thing too.”

Ryoka blinked.

“You did?”

The innkeeper girl smiled as she recalled.

“Back home—I’d get a bag of chips, one of those big ones from the store, a full water bottle, and a couple of blankets and then get my laptop to watch TV all night...or play chess.”

She wagged her eyebrows at Ryoka, which made Mrsha immediately place a paw over them. Ryoka grinned as she sat down again. There was no hesitation now as she spoke, confiding a secret to Erin and the distracted Mrsha.

“When I was a kid, I’d buy food and then try to hide somewhere in the house so my dad couldn’t make me go to formal events. One time I hid in a closet and no one could see me when they opened the door. I spent two days in there, sneaking out to use the bathroom at night.”

Erin laughed in delight. Ryoka grinned, although internally she winced at the memory. Her little game had ended when the police had shown up to take her parents’ statement. They’d thought she’d either run away (again) or been kidnapped.

The idiot she’d been in the past helped the Ryoka of today, though. Erin was laughing at the memory, and right on cue, the door opened and Mrsha sat up, wagging her tail as a [Receptionist] carefully edged into the room with food.

It was a cheese platter after all. Ryoka blinked down at it, surprised that people in this world *had* cheese platters. And more food came—and pillows! Erin and Ryoka put the food on the table and Mrsha began scarfing some of it down. But all too soon the Gnoll cub was pacing around the room, too full for snacks.

“Uh oh. I think Mrsha wants to go somewhere where there’s more stuff.”

Erin looked concerned as Mrsha stood up and clumsily tried the door handle. The Gnoll looked pleadingly at Ryoka, who frowned at this second unexpected conundrum.

“Maybe she can go downstairs? There’s more space down there and I think she could hang out with Garia and Fals. They’d love to spoil her, I’m sure.”

Erin nodded hesitantly.

“Are you sure it’ll be safe?”

Ryoka had to think about this, and because it involved Mrsha, she double-checked her own thoughts.

“Persua’s gone, and her little gang revolved around her. More importantly, both Fals and Garia are there. They’re responsible and I think Garia would put someone’s head through a wall before she let anyone hurt Mrsha. I’ll go with her and ask if it’s okay.”

A few minutes later Mrsha happily bounced downstairs with Garia and Fals laughing and promising to buy her some dried jerky. Ryoka took a seat in the room and found a pillow on her chair. Erin was already sitting on hers.

“Double padding. See?”

Ryoka smiled. The tension was gone now, and she felt like she could talk. She sighed as she closed the door.

What should she say? This time Ryoka knew the answer. Whatever came to mind. Whatever she *needed* to say. Because she was beginning to remember it now. This was how it went. She had a friend. And what could you tell a friend, a true friend, a good friend?

Anything.

“I worry about her you know.”

“Who? Mrsha?”

Ryoka nodded. Erin had a piece of cheese on a jam bun and she was nibbling at it. Ryoka picked up a bit of goat’s cheese and stared at it. She popped it into her mouth and swallowed before speaking.

“She’s my responsibility. Her tribe sacrificed themselves so she and I could get away. I...just don’t know how to look after her. I’m not a mother, and I can’t stay with her all the time.”

“I don’t think you have to. Lyonette’s here and I am happy to have Mrsha in my inn.”

“I know. And I’m grateful. But it’s not fair to Mrsha. She deserves someone to look after her.”

“And it has to be you?”

“Well yeah—”

Ryoka paused, thrown by the question. Erin was staring at her.

“She’s my responsibility.”

“But that doesn’t mean you can’t get help, right? I talked to Krshia, and she’s teaching Mrsha some days. And Selys helps babysit her on her days off...I think Mrsha’s really happy here. If you spend a lot of time with her when you’re here, what’s the problem? She knows you’re a Runner. Just be nice to her and hug her a lot whenever she’s around.”

For a while Ryoka stared at Erin. She opened her mouth, closed it. And then she laughed.

“Damn. No wonder people come to you for advice.”

The other girl blushed a bit.

“I dunno about all that. I’m just saying things how I see it. Mrsha’s part of the inn, now. I can’t imagine not waking up and having her try to eat everything in sight.”

They laughed at that. They laughed, and a bit more of the invisible wall they’d built up broke away soundlessly. It was only a wall if you thought it was a wall. And this was the feeling Ryoka had craved.

This was the feeling Erin had craved. The innkeeper sat across from Ryoka, staring at her friend. She’d almost forgotten what it was like to speak with Ryoka. The other girl was tall, Asian—the most unique Human-shaped person in the area, aside from maybe Revi or Octavia. No one looked like her.

And Erin could talk to her about things only Ryoka could understand.

Ryoka had discovered the joys of a brie-like cheese, close in texture, but slightly greenish and with a sharper tang to the flavor than she was used to. She offered some to Erin, and Erin declined. She had a lovely striped cheese that went very nicely with a bit of dried plum on the platter.

“So what really happened while I was gone? How’d you get back? Was everything really okay?”

For a second Erin’s mind went blank as Ryoka asked the question. She thought of everything that had transpired since she’d left Celum. She took a deep breath, put down her food, and looked at Ryoka, happiness gone.

“I killed Toren.”

Ryoka froze. She looked at Erin.

“You met him? Did he try to attack you?”

The other girl shook her head.

“No. I never saw him after he ditched me. But I heard—oh, Ryoka. I heard a lot of terrible things.”

She told Ryoka about Toren. How he’d attacked people on the road, ambushed travelers, and how she’d told Pisces to cut her mana supply. Ryoka clenched her fist, crumbling a cracker to dust in her hand as she listened.

“I’m sorry about that.”

“You warned me. I should have listened.”

There were no words for the guilt Erin felt. Ryoka nodded, looking upset.

“I did. But I didn’t think he’d suddenly start killing—I wonder if something Pisces did went wrong? Or maybe it’s because he could level... anyways, that’s really...are you sure he’s dead?”

“What?”

“Rule of monsters, Erin. In every scary movie, in every video game... the monster’s not dead until you see the body. And sometimes, not even then.”

Ryoka stared at her friend. Erin had frozen in her seat.

“You think Toren’s alive? But I cut his mana supply...”

“Maybe he had a mana potion? Or...is there a way to generate mana on your own? Could he have found another master or something? This is reality, not a movie, Erin. But we *are* in a fantasy world.”

“I know. I get it. I’ll—I’ll keep an ear open. If anyone talks about a skeleton, I’ll know.”

Erin sat with her hands woven together, staring down at the table. Ryoka stared at her and coughed.

“Sorry. I didn’t want to—look, it’s just a thought.”

“I know. And I did more than just kill Toren, I mean, that was like the last thing that happened. Actually, a *lot* of things happened while you were gone! What happened to you? I heard Magnolia spirited you away when you went to Ocre to visit Ceria and the others. What did she want?”

Ryoka shrugged.

“The usual. Threats, interrogation, intrigue—”

“Aw. Did she try and charm you as well?”

“That was the first thing she did! God—I could have kicked her ass, but not with Ressa there. Oh!”

Ryoka snapped her fingers. The sound was a *crack*—in the small room it was like a gunshot. Erin jumped.

“That’s *loud!*”

“Sorry. But you don’t know! Guess what I found out on the way to Magnolia’s mansion? Ressa’s not just a [Maid]. She’s a [Ninja].”

“What? You’re joking.”

“I’m sure of it. I saw her toss a throwing star at a bunch of Goblins that ambushed the carriage. And after that, when Magnolia was attacked by the assassins, she was fighting them like—”

“*What?* An assassin attack?”

“Oh, yeah. That.”

Ryoka waved a hand airily, concealing a grin. Near-death experience and horrifying trauma were fun to joke about after the fact.

“That happened right in the middle of our chat. Didn’t you have an assassination attempt when you visited her?”

“No I didn’t! Spill! What happened? Is Magnolia okay?”

“Well, I think she’ll have to do some remodeling, but her shrubbery was only partially consumed by the fire—”

Ryoka ducked as Erin threw a bit of cheese at her. She laughed, and then stopped laughing when she told Erin about the people who’d died. Erin listened, almost in tears when she heard about the servants who’d been killed as the assassins went after Magnolia, agog when she heard about Magnolia’s death-ray ring...and then she told Ryoka about returning to Esthelm, about talking with Pawn about Christianity...

Sometime after they’d been talking, the bit of cheese was eaten by Mrsha, who slunk into the room to grab as much food as she could carry and escape. Ryoka and Erin were sitting together by this point, laughing and talking to each other freely.

“It was just for a few weeks, but it feels like months, doesn’t it?”

Erin nodded, sipping from her cup as Ryoka filled hers from a pitcher filled with ice cubes.

“I did so much! I helped run Agnes’ inn, I made a bunch of weird food at Octavia’s shop, I helped start an acting troupe and got a magical door—”

“Hold up. *What* was that? Acting? You’re joking with me.”

“Nope! We should stop by the Frenzied Hare before we go back to Liscor. I can introduce you to Wesle and Jasi—they’re putting on a performance of *Othello* this week, I think!”

Ryoka stared at Erin. She stared at her cup. She slowly filled her mouth with liquid and looked at Erin. The girl raised her hands.

“Don’t you dare spit it on me! No!”

When Ryoka had swallowed and Erin had explained, the conversation halted and stopped on Erin’s private indignation with Miss Agnes, whom she’d had less and less contact with since returning to Liscor.

“Can you believe her? I mean, she didn’t want to help Jasi at all! It was like she didn’t even care!”

Ryoka could only shrug. She wanted to ask, ‘what did you expect?’, but then she looked at Erin and realized the other girl had expected more of Agnes.

“Honestly, I’m not surprised, Erin. Agnes is, well, an ordinary woman. She might be nice to her friends and people who help her out, but she’s not going to stick her neck out for other people.”

“I thought she was a good person.”

Erin sighed as she fiddled with a cracker. Ryoka’s mouth twisted.

“She’s just a person. Not bad, not good. She might help a bit if she has the means, but she’s not like you, Erin. She’s not...worth thinking about.”

“But she was so nice and welcoming. How could a woman like that just not care? Jasi was so tired—and hurt! She was practically missing all the scales on her hands! Are people just like that?”

Ryoka’s head bowed.

“Maybe. Maybe they’re all like that.”

Erin stared at her. Ryoka ran her hands along the edge of her chair as she spoke.

“That’s how I used to think. I’d look at news stories of people letting dictators get away with crimes, or turning a blind eye to crimes or not doing anything when there’s a problem. Or if they did, it was something small. Something I thought was worthless, like one of those food drives where you donate bits of food and ship it off to another country. Ordinary people did just enough to make themselves feel good and let other people do the actual work.”

“Sometimes that’s all you can do.”

Erin’s voice was soft. She looked at the table.

“Sometimes you can only do a bit, Ryoka.”

Ryoka nodded.

“Yeah. I realized that when I tried to do the right thing. It’s really hard. Really, really hard. Half the time it seems like there’s no answer, no good way to fix what’s broken. The other half, it feels like if everyone would just work together we’d solve the problem. But we never do.”

Erin stared at a wall. When she spoke, it was quietly, thoughtfully.

“I don’t think it’s fair to ask random people to fix problems. I think we’ve got to work together, so if there’s something I need to do, I’ll ask people I can trust. My friends.”

“But if you do that, what about the world?”

She shrugged. Erin pointed to the closed window.

“I don’t know about the world. I can’t imagine trying to solve world hunger, or—or cure cancer. And there’s no internet here. No way to talk to people. But I can help people around me. That’s what I did at Esthelm.”

“You did do that.”

Ryoka still couldn’t believe Erin had managed that. She’d saved a city. Or maybe...helped them save themselves. Erin nodded.

“I think you’re sort of right, Ryoka. In our world it’s really hard to do stuff. There’s laws and jerks and so many problems. And we’re not rich or powerful or famous. Maybe in our world we can’t do anything. But here, I know the second-most important guy in Liscor’s Hive, and I know a Drake [General], a bunch of Gold-rank adventurers, and I played chess with Magnolia. I can do something, I think. I can help people. It’s just that I’m so busy...”

“Yeah. That’s one of the things I wanted to talk to you about.”

Ryoka sat up in her chair. Erin was trying to juggle crackers and failing. She looked at Ryoka.

“I just don’t know what to do. I love all my new customers and I’m making money hand over fist with all the Gold-rank adventurers. It’s just I don’t have *time*, and Lyonette’s overworked as it is...”

“So hire someone.”

Erin blinked at Ryoka. Ryoka stared at her.

“I mean, maybe you don’t want to, but I think you have to at this point, Erin. You could have someone do a trial and maybe it’ll be tough sorting things out, but if you can get an actual staff—”

“No, I think you’re right. I just forgot I could do that. Hire someone. Okay. Yeah, that’s a good idea!”

Ryoka stared. She stared so hard her eyes felt like they were going to fall out. Erin shifted uneasily.

“What?”

“You forgot you could hire people?”

“I’m new to this innkeeper thing, okay? I kept thinking ‘this is my inn, so I’ve got to do everything’. I only hired Lyonette because I thought she’d die in the cold by herself. But I guess I never thought about getting a new [Barmaid] or [Cook].”

“So you’re going to do it?”

Erin nodded, smiling.

“Yeah. I can do it. I’ll do it tomorrow, or maybe later today. Actually, I’ll look into it after we finish talking.”

“What?”

“I’ll go hire someone. You’re right. Selys always said I should. I’ll go have a word with Safry and Maran tomorrow. They’re both [Barmaids]. They should know some good people I could interview, right?”

Ryoka hesitated. Erin’s turnaround from thought to action was so fast she was having a hard time keeping up.

“I mean, we could think this through some more. Have you thought about hiring a Drake or Gnoll? It might help if they know more about local customs. How much will you pay them?”

Erin shrugged.

“I don’t know. I’ll figure it all out as I go. That’s how I roll.”

Ryoka stared, but since she’d done that and Erin seemed immune to it, she switched topics.

“Okay, about Pawn.”

“What about him?”

Erin looked confused. Ryoka replayed parts of their catching up she’d done.

“You said you were telling him about the bible, right?”

“Yeah...well, he was asking. And he was really confused, so I...”

Erin hesitated. She vaguely recalled Ryoka’s admonitions not to bring up religion.

“Was that a bad thing?”

There was a right way to respond and a wrong way. Ryoka had done the wrong way, once. She remembered shouting at Erin, calling her an idiot and then getting punched halfway into oblivion. She bit her lip.

“I think...it might have been a mistake. But it’s what Pawn needed. I’ll have a talk with him. But this god thing...”

“I know. Gods are a bad thing. The crusades and the inquisition, right?”

“Something similar. But if Klbkch is okay with Pawn...well, I’ve just got a lot to do around here.”

“So do I! I think I need to talk to Klbkch too, Ryoka.”

“Oh?”

“Yeah. I was thinking of expanding my inn, actually.”

“What, just like that?”

“Well obviously I need to see how much it will cost. But my rooms are all sold out and I think Ceria and the others are getting tired of sleeping in the basement. If I could get the Antinium to build me a third floor or maybe a second wing...”

“You’ll definitely need more staff if that’s the case.”

“And a [Cook]! I’m telling you Ryoka, if I didn’t have to keep making food all day that would free me up *so much*. Forget a [Barmaid], a [Cook] is what I really need. But it’s so hard finding people with [Advanced Cooking]—apparently people with that Skill are sort of rare. I don’t want to pay too much for someone, you know?”

Ryoka nodded thoughtfully. She had a sudden thought.

“You said you leveled up, right? You got that magical ambient energy and a skill that kept everything fresh, right?”

“Right!”

Erin nodded happily. Her becoming a [Magical Innkeeper] had been one of the highlights of her recent past. Ryoka smiled as her thought became an idea, and an excellent one.

“If that’s the case, maybe you don’t need a [Cook] after all.”

“What do you mean?”

Erin was curious. Ryoka smiled.

“You have a Skill that keeps food fresh, right? If that’s the case, why not prepare everything a few days ahead of time rather than worrying about it?”

She was opening her mouth to object when Erin realized what Ryoka was saying. Her eyes widened.

“You mean—”

Ryoka nodded, grinning widely in anticipation.

“I mean cook *everything*. Take a day and just make food for twelve hours straight. You can store it wherever you like and serve it whenever you need to! For that matter, don’t worry about mealtimes. Just make breakfast, lunch, and dinner all together. Because if the food doesn’t lose its freshness...”

“I can just reheat it! I could have a month’s worth of food ready and all Lyonette has to do is warm it up and serve it!”

Erin leapt to her feet. She threw her hands up and danced about, laughing excitedly.

“Ryoka, you’re a *genius*!”

“I’d like to think so. Speaking of which, when we get back I want to test that magical door of yours. It’s...frankly, it’s mind blowing.”

“Isn’t it incredible?”

“Yeah, but it could be *more* incredible, Erin.”

“What do you mean?”

Thoughtfully, Ryoka glanced at the window, which was again, less than scenic since the shutters were closed.

“There has to be a way to utilize all that mana your inn is producing.”

“I thought it would be good mostly for my door, actually.”

“Yeah, but—I bet the door doesn’t take up a third of your inn’s supply of mana. If that’s even how it works! I want to see how many people you could actually transport before it runs out of power and—I wonder how far you could send people with it? Could you send someone to say...Invrisil?”

Erin froze mid-tango. She gaped at Ryoka.

“Invrisil? Ryoka, you really think I could make my inn connect all the way over there?”

“It would help me out a lot, if you did.”

Ryoka’s mind was racing with possibilities. She frowned, thinking aloud.

“But that’s not all. I know there’s rune magic. Couldn’t you use the inn’s mana for some kind of spell?”

“Like what?”

“Like—well, you’ve already got the equivalent of a preservation rune on your whole inn...”

“Better.”

Erin smiled happily. Ryoka blinked.

“Oh? How so?”

“I could have gotten some runes on my pantry. I talked to this [Mage] who said he could put some on my pantry for...I think it was like forty gold coins? But it would only have been a shelf or two, and it wouldn’t be *total* preservation. He said it was more like it would slow down the rate at which food went bad. So I couldn’t just leave raw meat in there because it would still go bad pretty fast.”

“Huh. I guess [Field of Preservation] really is an incredible skill.”

“Right? What do you think I’d get at Level 40? Or Level 60?”

“I don’t know. A totally automated kitchen? Plates and dishes that automatically serve and wash themselves?”

“That would be *so cool*. Do you think—”

“Anyways, Erin. I was saying that you could have other runes. Like ones that heat up your inn, or cool it down. Or...or what about a rune that... distills water from the air? Is that possible?”

“Ooh. Useful! Let me write this down.”

Erin searched around for a bit of parchment as Ryoka kept talking.

“There’s so much I have to do there. I told you about Laken—”

“An actual [Emperor]! And he’s from our world! I want to meet him. And Durene!”

“I’m sure you’ll love him. But he’s so far away that even with Magnolia’s coach, it’s a day’s journey. But if you could get to Invril just by walking through a door—”

“The Runner’s Guild will get *really* mad if I start doing deliveries that way.”

“Maybe it can just be a personal connection? If people knew your door could do that, you might be in danger.”

Ryoka was thinking over the issue, looking for potential risks. Erin nodded, serious.

“I want to make my inn better. If I can link my inn to other cities, I’m totally down for it. And I like the idea of expanding the inn. And hiring more help. Especially hiring more help. I wonder if I could hire Garry? Or...”

She broke off, lapsing into thought. Ryoka stared at her friend. They’d covered a lot of topics, almost everything Ryoka had done and seen. She’d told Erin about the wand she’d sold to Hedault to equip the Horns of Hammerad. But there was one thing she hadn’t mentioned.

“Erin, there’s something I need to talk to you about. Magnolia and her assassins are one thing, but I ran into...something...as I was coming back

from Laken's village."

"What?"

Ryoka hesitated.

"I don't know. But it was...dark. No, that's not the word. Look, let me explain. It started when I was running through a blizzard. Ivolethe was guiding me since she can see through the snow, but she suddenly started getting lost. We ended up in a forest, and I had to build a fire since she and I couldn't find our way out. It was like we were trapped there. And then it started getting really dark..."

Erin's eyes widened as Ryoka told the story of the three visitors who sat around the campfire. Ryoka finished, telling Erin about hurling her fingers into the fire. She flexed her right hand as she did. She thought she could still feel the fingers. She could remember them *burning*.

"You'll probably think I'm crazy. But it was all true Erin, I swear. And Ivolethe knows something. She just won't tell me who—or what—they were."

She waited for Erin to laugh at her, or at least be a bit skeptical. That would be natural. But Ryoka's blood froze as Erin pulled something out of her pocket and told her what had happened to her on the Winter Solstice.

"Do you know what this is, Ryoka? It's a coin, but it doesn't look like it's silver."

Ryoka stared down at the bright, off-silver color and the faded inscriptions on the shiny metal. She felt it carefully and then put it down on the table.

"I have no idea. But you say some travelers gave it to you?"

Erin nodded.

"In exchange for the food. Not the gifts."

The gifts. An umbrella that contained the sun. A rope to hang yourself with and pretend to be dead. A horn—

Ryoka's skin erupted into goose bumps. She'd heard a horn while she sat around the fire. She stared at the coin and felt very, very cold.

“Who do you think they were? Do you think they were connected to the people you met?”

Carefully, using the tips of her fingers, Ryoka pushed the coin back across the table towards Erin.

“I don’t know. I don’t like it. Tamaroth? I’ve never heard that name before in my life...I think? But I’ll ask about it. I’ll ask Klbkch—”

“Why him?”

“He might know something. Look, until I can find out more, don’t show that coin to anyone you don’t trust, Erin. There’s someone else I can talk to besides Klbkch who might know.”

“Who? Teriarch?”

“Ye—how’d you know?”

“I met him.”

Erin blinked as Ryoka lurched up from her seat.

“You *met*—”

“Didn’t I say? Yeah! We met him on the road. He was looking for you, Ryoka. He wanted to know how to use it.”

Ryoka stared at Erin. She tugged at her ears when Erin described meeting Teriarch—appearing as his Human [Mage] form no less—and how Erin had taught him to play *Angry Birds*.

“Hold on, I need a break. Would you hand me a knife? I need to slice off my ears, because clearly I’m hearing things.”

“Don’t be dramatic, Ryoka! I really did meet Teriarch—he’s weird, like you said, but sort of nice! How did he duplicate your iPhone? Do you think he can do it for me if I ask?”

Ryoka put her head in her hands.

“Please stop talking. My head hurts.”

Her head really did hurt. Teriarch, out in the open? Playing crappy games? What did it mean? Was there a meaning? What could she do about it? Bash her head in with a rock? Forget? After a while, she looked up. Erin was gazing at her, grinning.

“Isn’t it weird?”

“What, specifically?”

“We keep running into the same people. You knew Octavia before I met her, and I met Teriarch...everything’s connected.”

“It’s a small continent. Just about the size of Eurasia.”

“Well, I think it’s awesome. And I also think...yeah, I think I know what to do.”

Erin smiled. Things felt clearer to her, as if a fog had lifted. Here was Ryoka, her friend. Maybe her best friend? Her friend from another world. And it felt like Erin had been waiting for a long time to talk to her. Not about anything specific—it was just that she needed to talk to someone.

“Build my inn, hire people, and sell food to adventurers. That’s my plan for now. What about you, Ryoka?”

The girl shrugged.

“I’m staying here for now. I’ve been away too long, and there’s so much I need to do. Ivolethe is going to teach me...something. Faerie magic, maybe. Or a way to run faster. I’ll go shopping—see if I can pick up some magical items and get Octavia to brew me some potions, but my goal is to become a Courier. If I can make it all the way to First Landing with my two feet, maybe I can see about getting a ship to go to Wistram.”

“That’s big.”

“Why aim low?”

“True.”

Erin played with a bit of cheese on the platter.

“Do you think we should go there? To Wistram?”

Ryoka stared out of the window. She got tired of staring at the shutters and opened them. A cold wind blew in, and Ryoka stared out across the city of Celum, at the rooftops full of snow.

“I don’t know. But I know that I need more...power. No, that’s not the right word. More strength, more speed, more...something. I need to protect

myself, and other people. Getting rich and learning to run faster is a way to do that.”

“I’d just like to earn more money. If I can make my inn better, well, then I think I can help other people. I could buy things for Mrsha, help out Ceria and the others...”

“Money makes the world go round.”

It was funny, but money was important. So important. Money could buy them safety, get them to Wistram, or maybe just protect them. Magical artifacts, [Barmmaids], toys for a Gnoll cub. Was there anything money couldn’t buy?

It was clichéd, but perhaps the answer was a friend. Ryoka reached for a pitcher, embarrassed at the very thought and found it was empty. Erin looked into her cup and found it was gone too. She shrugged to herself and then looked at Ryoka.

“Tell me about Invril. Did they have any cool fashions over there? Did you see anything interesting, or were you talking with that [Emperor] guy too much to notice?”

“Oh, I got an eyeful. Invril’s huge, Erin. It’s a real city. You’d either love it or hate it.”

“I think I’d love it...if they have cool stuff there.”

“They have ice cream.”

“No way!”

“Yes...way. They’re serving tiny spoonfuls out in silver bowls as if it were Häagen-Dazs. If you started selling ice cream over there, you’d be rich in no time.”

“Ice cream’s that popular? Well duh, it is, obviously. I should make some more. But do they have plays?”

“Not that I saw. You think you want to send the actors all the way to Invril?”

“Why not? They could start Hollywood over there!”

“More like the Globe Theatre.”

“The what?”

“*Shakespeare*, Erin. Don’t tell me your actors only know how to perform *Othello*.”

“Hey! The first thing I taught them was *Romeo and Juliet*!”

“Aw. *Romeo and Juliet*? Really?”

“Actually, this play was *Juliet* and *Romeo*. I also got them to do *Pygmalion*, and *Hamlet*...and *Frozen*...but I’m running out of plays to teach them.”

Ryoka laughed.

“I’d sell my left kidney to see them do *Chicago*. Or at least, one or two songs from it.”

“Well, why not? You could teach them how to do the acting.”

“No. I couldn’t!”

“Why not?”

Ryoka was trying to imagine a bunch of female Drakes, Gnolls, and Humans doing the Cell Block Tango scene from *Chicago*. Her imagination was having trouble processing the idea.

“No. That would be—”

She broke off. Erin was nodding and smiling expectantly.

“Yeah...?”

Ryoka hesitated. And then she grinned. When she was around Erin, it felt like she could really do anything. Nothing was too crazy with her.

“Let me see if I can remember the lyrics. No promises.”

“I want to see if they’ll perform in Liscor. It would be cool to have them perform in my inn. Or maybe somewhere more public? And I could sell my new magical foods as well!”

“Yeah, we need to have a talk about that stuff, Erin. I know it’s incredible that you can make magical food, but...Defense Soup, Erin? Really?”

“Hey! It’s hard to name this stuff. I thought about Thickskin Soup, but that sounds really nasty. Relc was calling it Scale Soup...”

Ryoka was laughing. Erin was waving her hands. At some point, they stopped talking about anything important. They cracked jokes, came up with ridiculous names to call their soup—they laughed and for a few moments, they weren’t trapped in another world. They were just friends, hanging out together.

And then, at some point, Erin had to go to the bathroom, and Ryoka realized Mrsha was back in the room and trying to get their attention. Erin sighed.

“I guess we should do something today.”

“I suppose so.”

Ryoka made a face as she lifted Mrsha up. She recoiled from the Gnoll’s breath.

“How much did they feed you, Mrsha?”

The Gnoll child lolled about in Ryoka’s arms, stuffed to the point of unconsciousness. Erin sighed as she looked about the room.

“I wish we could do this again.”

“Why not? We can come back here again. Next week, or sooner. Whenever you like. We’ve got plenty of time.”

Ryoka grinned at Erin, and saw the girl’s face light up in reply. She lifted Mrsha up with a grunt and walked towards the door. Beyond it lay the rest of the world. But somehow it wasn’t as daunting to face it. This moment had restored something Ryoka needed. Something Erin needed.

And both of them knew it. Erin spoke up as Ryoka opened the door.

“Hey Ryoka?”

“Yeah?”

The young woman turned at the door. Erin smiled at her.

“I’m glad you’re back.”

Ryoka turned away. She opened the door and Erin got up. The two stood at the doorway. Ryoka grinned.

“Let’s shake things up.”

Her name was Ivolethe. She was a Frost Faerie, at least to the people of this world. But that was a poor name for her true nature. But at the very least it hinted to her origin. She was no Human. She was not mortal.

And now she hovered in the snow, in the cold air, outside of a window. She could sense warmth from within, hear voices and laughter. Perhaps she might have entered, but there was cold iron in the walls of the building. And she was not invited.

Ivolethe hovered by the window, peering in through a crack. There were two girls sitting in the room. Erin Solstice and Ryoka Griffin. Ivolethe stared at Ryoka. Her friend. That a faerie could be friends with a Human was incredible. But Ryoka was still Human, still mortal. And there were ways in which she and Ivolethe could never truly understand each other. Yet they were friends, just as Ryoka was friends with Erin.

Ivolethe stared into the room as the two girls laughed and spoke. There was friendship there, still small, perhaps tenuous at times, but blooming and growing brighter in the cold. Ivolethe put her hand on the window’s ledge and took it away as the wood began to frost over. She looked into the bright room, and turned away.

Friendship. Ivolethe had it too. And it meant more to the Frost Faerie than Ryoka could know of for now. So Ivolethe flew. She flew high, high into the sky, and then south at speeds Ryoka could only dream of.

She flew south, coming to rest high in the air. Ivolethe looked down, and saw blood in the snow. She saw dead things.

And undead things. Two beings woven of magic and the grave stood in the snow, surrounded by children. Goblins. Armed children, a score of them, at least a hundred. Hobgoblins and Goblin warriors, fierce fighters in black armor.

They were all dead. The Goblins’ blood stained the snow. The two dead creatures stood among them, untouched. It had been a brief skirmish, and

completely one-sided.

Ivolethe watched as a larger force of undead, thousands, no, larger, approached. A detachment rode forth, proud warriors surrounding a Goblin that reeked to her of the same death the two undead had.

Here was a threat. One that Ivolethe might have dreamed of wiping out with an avalanche, or some other wrath of nature. Yet that would have been meddling on a scale that would surely cause repercussion. And... punishment.

So Ivolethe did not interfere. But she watched a bit of destiny play out as the undead duo stood among the deceased Goblins.

Venitra and Ijvani stood among the remnants of the dead Goblins that had ambushed them. She recognized them as belonging to the Goblin Lord's army, but she felt no qualms in butchering them. They, like all things not created of her master, were lesser things.

Still, she didn't attack the next group that surrounded her. Huge Hobgoblins and snarling Goblin elite warriors, Goblin [Shamans] and [Mages] who watched her with more fear than their warrior counterparts. So long as she was not attacked, Venitra would not harm the Goblins. Doing so would run counter to her master's plans.

"They attacked us when we requested to speak with you. Next time ensure they are not so foolish."

She was speaking to a Goblin who stood in front of her and Ijvani. He was pale and his eyes...there was something wrong with them. To Venitra, the eyes were reassuring, comforting, even. They reminded her of her master, Az'kerash. It might be presumptuous of the Goblin to emulate her master so and perhaps under other circumstances Venitra would have plucked the eyes out herself. But as it stood, Venitra considered the Goblin Lord an...ally of sorts.

He did not respond to her comment. None of the Goblins surrounding him could look at their leader, or at Venitra. Both were monsters, of a kind.

“We are headed towards Liscor.”

Ijvani’s voice was closer to a hiss, and there was an unsettling echo to her words. The Goblin Lord looked at her. He did not speak, but one hand rose and pointed.

Venitra and Ijvani turned. Ijvani stared at Venitra, and the woman made of bone didn’t meet her companion’s eyes.

“I told you we were going the wrong way.”

“We’ll adjust our course.”

Venitra turned back to the Goblin Lord. His eyes were fixed on her. She nodded at him.

“We shall leave you to your work. Oh. I should mention this—there are two Drake armies closing in on your position.”

The Goblin Lord nodded. Venitra had seen the armies as she and Ijvani had moved past them, undetected. She studied his face.

“Each one is about ten thousand strong.”

He grinned. And turned away. Venitra paused, and then turned. She and Ijvani began walking through the snow. To Liscor. To find the accursed Human named Ryoka Griffin.

“I told you we were going the wrong way.”

“Silence, Ijvani.”

The next day the two suppression armies sent to crush the Goblin Lord’s army met his in the hills a hundred miles to the southeast of Liscor.

4.12

Erin and Ryoka left the room in the Runner's Guild, a sleepy Mrsha draped in Ryoka's arms. They left as friends, refreshed, ready to face the world.

"Ryoka's back!"

Erin sang and danced down the steps, beaming in delight. She flexed her arms while Ryoka shifted the snoozing Mrsha.

"Erin and Ryoka, together again! The invincible duo!"

Ryoka smiled, embarrassed, and then covered it with a scowl.

"Stop that."

"Come on, don't you think we make a good team?"

"I think a good team doesn't brag about how good they are."

"But we're like a duo! You know, Bonnie and Clyde! Jesse and James! Bert and Ernie! Tom and Jerry! Uh...Batman and Robin!"

"Erin—"

"Siskel and Ebert! Spongebob and Patrick!"

"Which one are you, then?"

Erin hesitated.

"Uh...Sp—"

"You're Patrick."

"No...I don't want to be him."

"Well *I'm* sure as hell not Patrick."

"Okay, maybe that was a bad comparison. But I could be, uh—"

"I'm Batman."

"Aw."

Their banter was interrupted by a [Receptionist] who hurried to them on the stairs with a smile on her face.

“Miss Erin, Miss Ryoka, I hope your discussion was productive?”

“What? Yeah. Oh—right.”

The [Receptionist] was staring meaningfully at Ryoka. She hesitated, cursed internally, and then shifted Mrsha to fish at her belt pouch.

“Here.”

She handed the woman two gold coins. Both Erin and the woman’s eyes bugged out when they saw the glitter. The [Receptionist] gaped at Ryoka, and then hurriedly curtsied to Erin.

“I hope you enjoyed our brief hospitality, Miss Erin. Please, if there’s anything we can do, do not hesitate to ask.”

“Uh. Okay.”

When the woman had hurried off with the coins Erin grabbed Ryoka.

“What was *that*?”

Ryoka grinned.

“The Guild charges a 5% fee on all deliveries. I’ll do the paperwork later, but right now they think you just gave me a delivery worth forty gold coins.”

“But that’s so much! Ryoka—”

The Runner shook her head. She was in a good mood.

“I’ve got the money, and I think we got what we paid for, right? Private rooms, delivered food, entertainment for Mrsha...and I feel a bit bad for bullying that receptionist.”

“I guess...”

“Don’t worry about it. I’m not. Here, hold Mrsha for me, will you?”

Ryoka dumped Mrsha into Erin’s arms. The Gnoll grunted and Erin did too. Ryoka strode over to two Runners who were approaching her.

“Garia, Fals. Thanks for looking out for Mrsha.”

“It was our pleasure, Ryoka. That little furball can run pretty fast! Are you going to teach her how to be a Runner?”

“Who knows?”

Ryoka smiled at Fals and turned to Garia. The shorter Runner smiled at Ryoka with an awkwardness Ryoka recognized. She’d felt it herself not a few hours ago.

“Sorry for overfeeding her, Ryoka. She’s just so cute...”

“No problem. And I’m sorry I had to cut you off, but Erin and I really needed to reconnect. Uh...how’s it been, Garia?”

“Oh, you know. I’m just running deliveries. I don’t do anything *that* interesting...”

“Not like a Runner who made it to Invril in two days! I heard the rumors Ryoka—don’t tell me it actually happened?”

“Not quite. I hitched a ride, actually...”

Ryoka gave them a cut-down version of the events, minus the assassinations and heard their envious comments about getting to do that many deliveries at once. Then she got to the heart of the matter as she turned to Garia.

“Look, Garia, I’ve really dropped the ball on hanging out with you. You keep offering to do a delivery together and I’m always busy...I’m not a good friend.”

Garia turned bright red and waved her hands hurriedly.

“What? No, I know you’ve got a lot to do. I don’t think—”

“A good Runner makes time for friends, right Fals?”

The young man blinked at Ryoka, and then smiled.

“True enough! Are you planning on doing a delivery with Garia then, Ryoka?”

“Better. I was wondering if that offer to visit her family was still on the table. We could hang out for a day or two.”

Ryoka really had no desire to meet Garia’s family, but she had every desire to be a good friend to Garia, and from the way the girl’s face lit up,

that was the right thing to offer.

“Meet my family? Well—of course! They have a farm—we could have you over any time.”

“What about in a day or two? Maybe tomorrow? I’d hate to impose, but I don’t want to get tied up and not come...”

“No, no! They’d love to have you. I’ve told them all about you...”

Garia’s eyes slid sideways to Fals. Ryoka noticed, and turned towards him.

“Why not come with us? I’m sure Garia would love to introduce you as well.”

Fals looked surprised. He glanced at Garia and then met Ryoka’s eyes. She stared at him silently and he hesitated.

“I wouldn’t want to impose...”

“Well, what if I bring a friend? Garia, would you mind if Mrsha joined us? I think she’d love to see a farm.”

“No problem! And I bet she’d love to have fun with everyone...”

Garia was sneaking glances at Fals. Pressured on two fronts, he gave in graciously and smiled at Garia.

“I would be glad to. Just let me know when and we can run there together. Does your family enjoy sweets by any chance? I would love to buy them a jar of Miss Erin’s honey...”

“You don’t need to bring anything! Really!”

Ryoka participated in the conversation for a little bit, set up a tentative date, and then rejoined Erin, who’d persuaded Mrsha to walk on her own four paws. Her real struggle was making four paws turn into two.

“Come on, Mrsha. You can’t always run around on all fours. Krshia doesn’t do it.”

Mrsha gave Erin a glance that said quite clearly that Krshia was a fool who only walked upright to fit in. Erin smiled at Ryoka.

“Ready to go?”

“Yep. I’d say we’re in time for a late lunch if we get back to the inn now.”

“I just ate! Well, I guess I can make something if the adventurers are hanging about...”

Ryoka frowned, perplexed.

“Do they always stick around? I thought they’d have things to do. Like kill monsters or go into the dungeon.”

“Yeah, well, they don’t actually do that so much. Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers are always talking and making plans...some days they go in and come back really late, covered in all kinds of nasty stuff.”

“Well, hopefully Pisces is still about. I want to talk with him.”

Pisces was indeed still in the inn, drinking and talking with the other Horns of Hammerad. And Griffon Hunt. And the Halfseekers.

None of the adventurers had left the inn, although Zel had. They were all clustered in the center of the room, talking heatedly about some big discovery. Ryoka had to get Ceria to explain it to her while Erin went to make a late lunch.

“Some adventurers went into the dungeon, Ryoka! This team—they’re only Silver-rank. They’re called Vuliel Drae and they went down through that hole Mrsha fell into. Apparently there’s an entirely new section of dungeon down there!”

Ryoka stared at the adventurers as they fussed over a bit of parchment. She walked over, peered over Ceria’s shoulder and was treated to a very rough map.

Or rather, the copy of a map. As it turned out, Halrac had just gone into the city and come back with a map of the dungeon. It had been made by Vuliel Drae, a relatively inexperienced group of adventurers who’d descended into the new hole and come out with a rudimentary sketch of a

few passageways, a tale of running into half a dozen traps and monsters within the first hour, and the head of a monster no one could identify.

And an enchanted mace. It had sent ripples through the growing adventuring community within Liscor. Because it was proof the dungeon had treasure.

“Not just any treasure. High quality enchantments.”

Ulrien explained that to Ryoka, although she had a sense he was also telling her for Ksmvr and Pisces’ benefit. The Horns of Hammerad were listening intently to the Gold-rank adventurers talking. Despite Ceria and Yvlon’s experience, they were still juniors watching experts in their field work.

And argue. Seborn was talking about the mace, much to Jelaqua’s clear displeasure.

“It has some kind of auditory enchantment. It shrieks like a Death Wailer when you hit something, and everyone but the wielder is affected. I’d say the effect isn’t just sound-based—there seems to be some kind of immobility effect to it as well. So that’s two benefits. Too bad only one person can use it safely, but the cost—”

“Damn it, those bastards were already getting offers for the mace! It’ll probably sell for thousands of gold pieces!”

Jelaqua burst out and kicked a chair into the air. Lyonette screamed and ducked, but Moore caught the chair out of the air. He stared reproachfully at the Selphid.

Interestingly, Jelaqua blushed. Ryoka wasn’t sure she’d be able to with a dead body. But her cheeks did change color. They turned slightly orange, as if something *inside* the dead skin was heating up.

Disturbing, to say the least. Ryoka looked away as Jelaqua apologized to Lyonette. Ulrien, the other team leader, was less emotional.

“It was luck. Those adventurers were lucky to survive an encounter with the monster carrying the mace. It’s not like they made it to a vault or raided a monster’s lair.”

Halrac nodded and grunted.

“Word is they would have been completely wiped out if another adventurer hadn’t helped them out.”

“Who?”

“It’s unclear. Some lone adventurer with the ability to resist the mace’s effects. She slew the monster carrying it and got the team through several hallways filled with traps by all accounts. There was no name given—she’s described as a masked swordswoman with incredible talent.”

The other Gold-rank adventurers murmured at this. Typhenous raised his eyes at Revi and Ryoka saw the Stitch-girl shake her head. Jelaqua ground her teeth together.

“A lone swordswoman? Everyone’s getting the jump on us!”

Ulrien frowned at her.

“It’s not who’s fastest, Jelaqua. It’s who’s alive at the end to claim the treasure. You know that. Forget a lucky break; if just one of the dungeon’s treasuries is partially intact, we’ll reap a hundredfold times that amount.”

“I know. I just don’t like someone stealing a march on us.”

Jelaqua groused. She looked towards the kitchen and lowered her voice.

“Plus, you know those idiots wouldn’t have had the courage to descend, much less survive, without Erin’s cooking!”

Ryoka had been told all about the magical effects of Erin’s food. Not only could she make a soup that warmed you up when standing naked in the cold, but she could make one that toughened the skin, and another that made you stronger than you should be.

It was an incredible Skill with several caveats. You couldn’t have more than one effect at once, it wore off in a few hours, the food spoiled quickly, and Erin had to make it. Her or someone else with [Wondrous Fare]. And it was the exact sort of thing an adventurer might want, especially going into a dungeon. However...

“I’m not sure if they’ll conflict with our potions.”

Jelaqua had asked Erin to make her some of the Scale Soup, but she hadn’t had a chance to test it yet. She paced around the room, understandably anxious.

“Wouldn’t *that* be wonderful? Erin’s magical cooking helps all the low-level adventurers who can’t afford better enchantments, but we...”

Ulrien ignored his counterpart. The Halfseekers seemed used to Jelaqua’s emotions, but Griffon Hunt was methodical. He nodded to the others.

“I want to talk with the leader of Vuliel Drae. See if he can describe these Gnoll-like monsters. I hear they brought back a head.”

Seborn nodded.

“Some of the Gnolls were quite agitated when they saw it. They may know more.”

“I’ll inquire about it.”

Halrac left with Seborn, the two being the most knowledgeable about the monsters. Ulrien and Jelaqua went to track down the leader of the adventurers who’d gone into the dungeon.

“They’re probably at the bottom of a barrel of ale and celebrating. Still, I want to know what it was like in detail.”

That left Typhenous, Revi, and Moore. Ryoka was surprised the [Mages] didn’t have their own duties, but then she saw all of them sitting down and eating Erin’s magical food, with varying degrees of enjoyment.

“See, I can make the Corusdeer Soup into a patty. And the uh, Scale Soup becomes...”

Revi paused as something went *crack* inside her mouth. She spat out what she’d eaten and stared at a hard fragment in horror.

“Ew! What *is* that?”

“A uh, Stonelizard scale. But I boiled it!”

“Is that *lemon and mint*? And...fish?”

“It tastes better than it does as a soup!”

“Gah. That’s hardly an improvement.”

Revi made a face. Moore, chewing down his food, shrugged his huge shoulders.

“You must admit it still tastes a thousand times better than some potions.”

“True. Now, to see how it might conflict with spellcasting and other enchantments.”

Typhenous pushed his plate back and began rummaging at his belt for a potion. Ryoka turned to the Horns of Hammerad, who’d been talking amongst themselves.

“How are you all doing?”

“We’re wondering whether we should be looking into this dungeon too, honestly.”

Ceria confessed to Ryoka as she watched Typhenous carefully imbibing part of a potion and making a disgusted face. She sighed as she scratched at her bone hand. Ryoka looked at her hand and then glanced at her missing fingers.

“It sounds intense down there. I hope you’re thinking it over carefully.”

The half-Elf nodded seriously.

“We learned our lesson once, Yvlon and I. But honestly Ryoka, there’s not much else we can do around here. Monster hunting around Liscor isn’t exactly a lucrative business, especially in the winter. Plus, I’ve seen Rock Crabs and I don’t want to tangle with them, even with our new gear. We could look for work around Celum thanks to the magical door, but...”

She shrugged, making a face.

“We’re talking it over. Which reminds me, we need to pay you...”

“I’d like to say it was between friends, but I wouldn’t say no to gold either. Still, you did get Erin back to Liscor for me...”

“We owed *her* for that. Come on, if you want one of our artifacts or the gold that [Enchanter] gave you...”

Ryoka was sorely tempted to see what she might ask for, but she had something else on her mind right now. She hesitated.

“I’ll think about it. But could I borrow Pisces? I need his help for some research.”

“Research? Hey Pisces! Get over here! What are you looking into?”

Ceria eyed Ryoka curiously as Pisces walked over, looking disgruntled at being summoned.

“Ah, Miss Ryoka. What may I help you with? Or am I not permitted to know the details of this endeavor either?”

Ceria stamped on Pisces’ foot and he hopped around, shouting while Ryoka explained. The [Necromancer] stopped yelping and his eyes lit up when she mentioned the door.

“Ah, a project to measure the door’s capacity? Well now, *that* is an interesting subject. May I take it that you intend for me to test the limits of the enchantment?”

Ryoka nodded.

“Is there some way to tell how much energy the door consumes? Definitely, I mean.”

Pisces sniffed.

“Well, Erin did manage to find the effective limit by jumping through it repeatedly. But I suppose that is not the aim of your inquiry?”

Ryoka gave him a look.

“Jumping through a door isn’t exactly a precise measurement. I’m just asking if there’s a way to calculate exactly how much energy is used per transportation. Is there a limit to weight or mass? How does distance affect the drain? Can you reduce the magic consumed into a figure and derive the maximum travelable distance from that figure?”

Ceria’s eyes went slightly cross-eyed, but Pisces’ eyes lit up. He stared curiously at Ryoka for a second and then smiled.

“Astounding. You seem to have a fascinatingly astute mind for magical theory. Have you some kind of connection with the [Engineer] class, by any chance?”

Ryoka smiled slightly.

“You could say that. Will you help?”

“I have nothing better to do, and the subject interests me as well. Very well.”

Pisces and Ryoka strode over to the door, Mrsha padding over behind them and watching curiously as they bent over the door. The Gnoll stared as Ryoka and Pisces opened the door and started chatting about the effects of the teleportation spell. She got bored and watched Revi poking herself with a dagger. Pisces and Ryoka’s conversation wasn’t exactly riveting.

“I understand that Erin’s new Skill provides the inn with a lot of mana. How fast does it replenish, though?”

“If it works under the principle of a site of high ambient magical power, like a mass graveyard or perhaps Wistram Academy for example, it would be a daily influx of energy with a set upper limit to the environs. However, I believe it is the door’s individual capacity that should be measured.”

“Oh? You’re saying the enchantment can only hold so much mana itself?”

Pisces sniffed.

“Naturally. This enchantment is built into the very wood and is of exceptional quality, but the most complex ward or binding has its limit. That is why the best enchantments on weapons, or objects such as this door, have mechanisms that allow them to recharge themselves.”

“So that’s our variable. Right. Well, if we’re testing how many times it can be used, we need to tell how much the maximum *is*.”

“There are several ways to determine that. But I believe exhausting the supply and deriving the limit from usage would be easiest.”

“Right. But just teleporting to Celum gives us only one variable. I’m suggesting that I teleport from set distances—”

“Naturally, *naturally*. We must account for the variable of distance as well as mass and weight. You need not lecture me on basic theory... although I am surprised I need not do the same for you, Miss Griffin.”

It was surprising, but Pisces understood the theory of the scientific inquiry, even if he didn’t have the terminology. But he knew the need to account for variables, and how to assign units to calculate the amount of mana used by the door.

In fact, the discussion made part of Ryoka's mind light up. She hadn't thought in terms of calculation or figures since coming to this world. And apparently, [Mages] shared at least a few genes with mathematicians, because their conversation attracted Typhenous' attention.

"Ah, Miss Griffin and young Pisces. May I ask what your fascinating discussion is about?"

The older [Mage] came over and in seconds, was engrossed in the idea of testing the limits of the door's ability to teleport. Pisces had already created a second 'anchor' which could be used to teleport back and forth—it was a mug.

He'd been drinking out of it and it was the closest thing to hand. Ryoka upended it and let a few drops fall onto the floor before she agreed to carry it a mile from the inn. But they still had to find a way to measure how much energy was being used each time she teleported.

"My suggestion would be to use a simple cantrip to do the measuring. You see, it is possible to draw from the door's capacity. Thus, the change in the size and intensity of a [Light] spell linked to the door's mana supply would indicate the reserves contained within the enchantment."

Typhenous stroked his white beard importantly as Ryoka did some warmup stretches for her legs and arms and Pisces squatted by the door. The [Necromancer] smiled.

"Ah. That is interesting. What if I were to use this as a benchmark?"

He raised his hand and his other palm on the door's surface. Ryoka blinked, and then felt every hair on her head try to stand up. She swore and ducked as a thin column of electricity burst from Pisces' hand and shot across the room. Yvlon and Lyonette jumped out of the way, the armored woman cursing at Pisces.

"Watch it! I'm wearing *metal*, you crazed maniac!"

Pisces ignored her. The thin, crackling stream of electricity had formed a straight line that shot out and then began to earth itself on tables a good twelve feet away from where he was standing. Mrsha got close, reached out at the bright crackling bursts of energy, thought better of it, and scampered away.

“Pisces! What are you doing?”

Erin shouted at him. The [Necromancer] stopped casting the spell and carefully walked over to where the spell had stopped. He marked the edge of the spot where the electricity had reached and marked the point with a cup. He turned to Typhenous and Ryoka and smiled.

“[Lightning Jolt]. Simple, and relatively costless. I am naturally using the ambient mana to fuel the spell while drawing on minimal reserves of my own.”

Typhenous nodded appreciatively while Ryoka went over to Erin and explained why she *shouldn't* hit Pisces with a pan.

“Only naturally. But can you keep your own output steady, young mage?”

Pisces smiled archly at him.

“My control is sublime, Typhenous. I shall cast the spell again once Ryoka has teleported the first time. And if we have a measuring tape, we may derive a very rough estimation of how the range of the spell decreases with each casting...”

“Right. So if we assume that was close to 100%, we're at...about twelve and a half feet. And if I hop through the door and come back—two teleports...Pisces, will you do that again?”

Pisces obliged. This time everyone watched as the lightning shot out... and stopped a bit before the place where Pisces had marked with his cup.

Ryoka blinked as Pisces placed a spoon on the second spot.

“Oh wow. That doesn't go down much. We might have to break out a ruler after all.”

“Well, a rough estimate is possible. I conclude that the distance of the first spell was roughly twelve and two thirds feet, Miss Griffin. As for the second measurement, it would be fair to say the spell decreased in length roughly two to three inches. With rough estimation, that would mean the distance of one hundred and fifty two inches decreased by three inches per two jumps, which would mean...”

Ryoka did the math faster than Pisces could.

“You could bring over fifty people to the inn and back before it ran out of juice. But that doesn’t account for how fast the door recharges.”

Pisces stopped. He blinked at Ryoka and cleared his throat. Ryoka saw Ceria sniggering at the [Necromancer] behind his back.

“Ah...yes. That is correct. Well, we shall account for those elements as well. Once the door’s mana is fully depleted, measuring the length of the [Lightning Jolt] spell after a set period of time would allow us to calculate the rate of passive mana absorption.”

Typhenous nodded.

“Of course.”

From her kitchen, Erin scratched her head. She looked at Ryoka and shrugged her shoulders.

“I don’t get it.”

Ryoka did. It wasn’t difficult math, although all the variables meant they’d need a lot of data to get good results. She saw Lyonette was watching them curiously, as was Mrsha. Yvlon and Ceria on the other hand looked like they weren’t able to follow the conversation at all. Ksmvr seemed to get it, but he was showing solidarity with his other teammates by pretending to be disinterested. And Revi was still poking herself with a dagger.

“Ow! Typhenous, we’re supposed to be testing the food, not checking on the stupid door!”

“Indulge me, please, Revi. I do enjoy this. And I seldom have the opportunity to speak with minds of similar inquiry.”

Typhenous waved at Revi and got a glare in response. From his seat on the floor, Moore got up and stepped carefully over to the mages and Ryoka. He smiled at them.

“I too would like to observe. And may I ask whether you intend to use the door as an involuntary translocation spell or as a portal effect? That may have a bearing on the mana cost.”

Typhenous and Pisces looked appraisingly at Moore. The half-Giant smiled at them. Typhenous cleared his throat.

“I believe young Pisces and I agreed that maintaining the portal effect was most efficacious. The natural caveat was that suddenly running out of mana would adversely affect someone caught in the middle of transportation—but I am pleased to report that testing finds this to be untrue.”

The other adventurers rubbed at their ears. Ryoka just rolled her eyes. [Mages] loved their fancy words, as much as any scholar. Mrsha shook her head and padded away and Erin went back into her kitchen, grumbling about an ‘older Pisces’. But Moore just nodded.

“I see. And the reason is?”

Pisces smiled and answered for Typhenous.

“Accidental transportation. If it were immediate, any contact with the door might trigger it, or a method of activation might be needed, all of which is far more complicated. An open portal allows for less disorientation as well.”

“Very true. Ah, I see that Pisces has managed to alter the enchantment. Miss Ryoka, will you be carrying this marker out to distances for us to test with?”

Moore handed the quite ordinary ceramic mug to Ryoka. She nearly dropped it and stared up at the half-Giant. Talk to him like a normal person. She knew that, but she had a horrible, horrible urge to call Moore a different name. She couldn’t help it. If he started waving around a pink umbrella, she’d really be in trouble.

“That’s right Ha—uh, Moore. I’ll run it out one mile to start and we’ll see how much energy that requires.”

Typhenous nodded.

“We may have to rely on a more precise spell to measure the energy consumption. I will consult with Moore and Pisces, although I believe a restrained [Flame Jet] spell would be more precise.”

Moore looked concerned.

“The inn *is* made of wood, Typhenous.”

“True. What would you suggest?”

Moore smiled and tapped the ground lightly with his huge staff. The floorboards suddenly sprouted a line of grass that shot forwards and ended at Ryoka's foot. She gaped at the grass until it withered and faded, seconds later.

"Simple, accurate, and less dangerous to Miss Erin's guests and her inn. Wouldn't you agree?"

Pisces and Typhenous exchanged a glance. Then they stepped aside so Moore could get a better look at the door. They began speaking all at once as Ryoka grabbed the mug and headed towards the door. Pisces stroked his hairless chin in an imitation of Typhenous as he chattered with the others.

"For the purposes of experimentation, we must naturally use the instantaneous teleportation effect..."

"But how to differentiate between the costs for portal-style teleportation and instantaneous?"

"What if we configured the door leading to Celum and measured the difference between the two for the mana cost?"

"Of course. But if we *are* accounting for the variation in distance, we should also take measurements at different distances than simply one mile. I propose a sample at one mile, five, ten..."

"Only naturally. Has anyone a piece of parchment? I have a sheaf and some ink in my room if necessary."

Pisces produced a slip of folded parchment. Moore opened his spellbook and took out a magical quill that needed no ink. Typhenous rubbed his hands together.

"Ah, good friends, it is a privilege to be working together with such fine minds. Shall we begin?"

"They're all nerds."

Erin peered at the three mages standing around the door with narrowed eyes. Ceria paused as she gulped down the spicy meatballs made in Drake fashion. They were on a skewer, and meant to be dipped in a sauce Mrsha had gotten all over the fur on her face.

“What’s a nerd, Erin?”

“Uh, someone who talks about a lot of complex and weird stuff?”

Erin wavered. She didn’t mean she actually thought Pisces, Typhenous and Moore were lame or deserved to have their pants pulled down or have their heads swirled in a toilet. Not that she’d ever seen that happen in real life. Besides, if anyone tried that to Moore, he’d probably throw them through a wall.

Maybe not. Moore was nice. Ceria just shrugged.

“I’m actually glad Pisces has found other [Mages] he can talk to.”

Erin looked at her half-Elf friend.

“You don’t talk with Pisces about stuff like that?”

Ceria laughed.

“What? Magical theory and numbers that don’t make sense? No way! I can’t follow what they’re doing. Calculating a door’s mana supply from a spell that makes grass? How would that even work?”

Erin vaguely understood what they were doing, because Ryoka had explained it briefly to her and because she’d had to take classes in algebra and so on in high school. But she wasn’t surprised no one else got it. It was surprising Ceria didn’t know.

“Wait, why don’t you understand? They’re talking about magic, right?”

“A *kind* of magic, Erin. They’re looking into the enchanting magic, but also spatial magic. Teleportation, you know? I don’t study that, and for good reason.”

Ceria put down her finished skewer of meat and grabbed another off of the plate. Across the table, Yvlon picked hers up and showed Ksmvr how to dip his with etiquette. On another table, Mrsha demonstrated how to eat like a savage. Ceria smiled as Lyonette tried to wipe Mrsha’s face and the Gnoll tried to avoid the clean cloth.

“Magic isn’t like that for me.”

“Really? What’s it like?”

“Magic is like...”

Ceria frowned. She conjured a small orb of water up with a flick of her hand, and as Erin watched, it fragmented into droplets and formed into a tiny replica of Ceria, which waved at Erin. Erin watched, open-mouthed as Ceria flicked the icy figure into the air. It shattered as it reached eye-level, and then landed on the table, a spatter of water droplets. Ceria breathed out and then grinned at Erin’s dumfounded expression.

“Whew, that’s tough. But magic is like that, see? I visualize my spells and put everything together just right. It’s hard to do earth magic and fire magic can get nasty if you don’t understand it right. But ice magic is like sculpting. You harden the ice here, lengthen it here...and you have a spike. It’s all seeing and concentrating, not...numbers.”

“Wait, so magic isn’t math?”

“Of course not!”

Someone interrupted their conversation. Erin looked over and saw Revi chewing on a meatball with a sour expression. The Stitch-girl’s tone was acerbic, but not exactly rude as she spoke to Erin.

“Magic isn’t the same for every mage, Miss Erin. Why would it be? Different schools use magic in different ways. Ceria specializes in destruction magic, in shaping her ice spells. But magic isn’t like that for me. I summon warriors. Magic is all about maintaining a link between myself and my spirits.”

“What’s it like?”

Revi hesitated. She drummed on the table and looked away before she replied.

“It’s rather like keeping a conversation up with all of my familiars. I have to maintain them, make sure there’s nothing wrong with their bindings, and I’m always looking for more. Magic is like collecting, exploring, augmenting what’s there. I slowly improve myself and the spirits I summon, buying new equipment for them, learning new ways to boost them with spells in combat...”

“Magic’s different for everyone it seems.”

Revi and Ceria nodded. Erin sighed. She *wanted* to learn magic, and knew that she couldn’t. Okay, in theory she could, but she didn’t have the raw talent or capacity Pisces and Ceria did. And...she didn’t really have the *time*. She had to get more help, like Ryoka said! It was just too bad she couldn’t throw around fireballs for fun now and then.

“Ah, is that food I see? Friends, let us adjourn for a moment.”

The other [Mages] had finally noticed that there was food on the tables. Typhenous, Pisces, and Moore came over to eat, and while they did Erin quizzed them on what magic was like.

Pisces snorted when he heard how Ceria practiced magic.

“Of course an [Elementalist] would think that way.”

Ceria threw a meatball at his head and he caught it in the air and levitated it onto his plate. Typhenous smiled at Erin and lowered his voice conspiratorially.

“Alas, it is the case where Revi and I have disagreed on the fundamentals of magic theory. A [Summoner] is...well, not the same as a general practitioner of the arts.”

“Up yours, Typhenous. Our spells are fine!”

“Yes, well, I’m sure they’re quite functional. For spells that require no adjustment and have little variation no matter how they’re cast.”

Pisces smirked and Typhenous smiled at him. Ceria muttered and flicked her fingers at them, showering the two [Mages] in snow. Typhenous blew it back at her and Revi hurled her plate at the two male [Mages].

There was a definite tension between the female mages and the male ones. Erin edged away. Mrsha and Lyonette stared at her as she joined their table.

“That wasn’t my fault.”

Someone *popped* into place in front of the door. Erin turned, and saw Ryoka, sweaty, looking about and scowling when she saw the eating mages.

“Hey! I just ran *five miles*. Get back over and finish testing!”

She snatched a plate full of the skewered meatballs from Moore and began scarfing them down, much like Mrsha. Actually, that was probably where the Gnoll was learning her table manners. Erin resolved to have a word with Ryoka about that.

While her friend was busy appearing and disappearing in the inn and the mages were arguing about the results, Erin had another visitor. It wasn't Pawn or Bird—Lyonette told Erin they'd gone back to their Hive, much to her disappointment.

Instead, Klbkch came into the inn, looking for Ryoka. He got Erin instead, and didn't seem put out by the trade.

"Sorry, Ryoka's busy teleporting. But if you have time, I'd love to talk."

"I have a reasonable supply of time, Erin. How may I help you?"

"I uh, I want to hire some of your people, Klbkch. And maybe upgrade my inn? Um. I can pay!"

Erin waited, looking hopefully at Klbkch as he sat with a plate of lukewarm meatballs in front of him. The Antinium Revalantor stared at her. He had a long gash down one arm, where the chitin was splintered. Was that new? Why hadn't he healed it? After a minute Klbkch shook his head slightly, as if coming to.

"Ah. You never cease to surprise me, Erin."

"Oh? Is that bad?"

"No. Rather...it would be fortuitous if not for the timing. May I ask what reason you have for this course of action?"

That was odd. Erin explained her problem with overwork as Klbkch nodded.

"Naturally this is an issue. So you wish to hire...?"

"Um. Garry? I know you've got lots of Workers and Soldiers, but I really need a [Cook]. And I get along so well with Garry and he's a friend, so..."

Klbkch drummed his fingers on the table, thinking. At last he slowly shook his head.

“I regret that I cannot allow Garry to work at your inn, although I will naturally consult with you about construction costs and options.”

“Aw. Why not?”

The Antinium paused, and for some reason, looked awkward. He clicked his mandibles a few times before replying.

“My Queen...is partial to Garry’s skill at preparing food. I do not believe she would allow him to work elsewhere no matter how much gold was offered.”

“You mean she likes his cooking?”

“...Yes.”

“Well, I mean, that’s a bummer. But it’s okay. She probably needs to eat a lot because she’s uh, so, so...grand. Big. Huge. Gargantuan. Which is a good thing! Right?”

Klbgkch wasn’t as quick to nod as Erin would have thought. He traced on the table with a finger, catching a tiny ant that had somehow wandered into her inn. He stared at it as Erin blinked at it and him. She wondered if he had a connection with—

He squished the ant and then picked up a meatball with the same fingers. Klbgkch ate it slowly as he spoke.

“The...Queens of the Antinium are naturally large. However, this is not due to their need to birth eggs. That method is inefficient and was removed from our process long ago. Rather, Queens are normally composed of an extensive matter of brain. Sometimes Queens had bodies that were two thirds thinking matter. However my Queen merely emulates that fashion.”

It took Erin a moment to figure out what he was hinting at.

“You mean she’s...fat?”

Klbgkch looked around the room slowly. Ksmvr sunk down low at his table as the Revalantor spotted him. Yvlon scowled at Klbgkch, but the Antinium just turned back to Erin and lowered his already quiet voice.

“I believe that she is the lightest of all the Queens on Izril by a considerable margin. She was the only Queen able to relocate herself to Liscor to start a new Hive, and as such she is still capable of movement.”

He paused and thought about that statement.

“For now.”

Erin had a horrible urge to start telling ‘yo mamma’ jokes about the Queen of the Free Antinium, but she resisted the impulse with difficulty. It wasn’t nice, although the Queen was a huge jerk. Plus, Erin couldn’t think of any good ones.

So instead she sighed and slumped over on the table.

“Too bad. I was really counting on getting Garry! But if the Queen wants her munchies...aw.”

Klbbkch regarded Erin for a moment.

“I regret that I cannot allow you to take Garry. However, I would have to say the same of Anand, Belgrade, and Pawn. They all fulfill important roles within the Hive, now.”

“Yeah. And what would I get them to do? I mean, I could have them help Lyonette, but they’re not [Barmaids]. I’m going to talk with Safry and Maran about that anyways...although I could use some guards.”

“Indeed?”

Erin nodded, thinking. She hadn’t discussed that with Ryoka, but Selys had always told her she needed help. Of course, she’d gotten Toren after that...Erin pushed away the memory.

“Someone to stay here while I’m out and all the adventurers are away would be good. I don’t like leaving Lyonette and Mrsha by themselves, even if there is a magic door to Octavia’s shop. For that matter, what if trouble comes in through the door?”

“Indeed. That is a quandary. Would you hire an adventurer?”

“Maybe...but they cost a lot! With how much I make, I’d only be able to hire one. And Selys says the job isn’t popular, I mean, a bouncer or a guard has to stand around all day.”

“Indeed. It is an unenviable task in many respects.”

Erin sighed, thinking out loud.

“What I really need is someone who’s patient. Someone I know—only all my adventurer friends *like* adventure. It’s their thing. But I need a guard, and not Wesle! Someone who never gets bored, who has practically no life...”

Erin chewed at her lip as Klbkch sat silently. She turned to look as Lyonette showed Mrsha how to dip her meatballs in some raw egg and eat it. Erin opened her mouth to ask if that was hygienic, remembered that no one besides Ryoka knew what that word meant, and then stared at the eggs.

The idea hit her in a flash of inspiration. She turned to Klbkch.

“What about Bird?”

“What?”

“Bird! What if I hired him?”

Klbkch stared at her. He visibly hesitated and glanced towards her window.

“Bird? He is unusual. Do you truly believe he would serve as an adequate guard for your inn?”

“Why not? He likes high places, and he likes sitting in one spot. He told me so. He can sit on top of my inn and shoot birds all day! Hold on—I’ve just had a great thought. Let me show you what I mean!”

Erin rushed into her kitchen and ran back to Klbkch with a piece of parchment and charcoal. She began sketching energetically.

“I told you I wanted to upgrade my inn, right? Well, I want a bigger common room—can you expand it like ten feet? And I want a third floor and longer second floor so I can have a lot more guests. But what if I added something on top of the third floor?”

It took Klbkch several minutes and a few questions before he could identify Erin’s sketch as a blueprint for the inn. What she had envisioned was a third floor for the inn, but her newest addition was a tall tower on top of the inn, a watchtower with no roof that would give anyone an unparalleled view of the landscape, much like the crow’s nest on a ship.

Erin grinned as she pointed to it and showed Klbkch a tiny stick-Antinium with a bow standing on the tower.

“He could sleep on the third floor and go up to the tower to shoot birds and watch out for danger. That’s all Bird does, right? And the tower would be totally cool! Doesn’t it look cool? I’ll call it...*the Bird’s Nest*.”

She waited. Klbkch stared at her. Erin coughed.

“That was, uh, a joke. You know, because of Bird and his name? And nest? And it’s tall?”

Klbkch nodded.

“I am aware. And if Bird agrees, I see no reason to object.”

“You mean you’d do it? You can build my inn?”

Erin sat up excitedly. Klbkch pored over the designs for Erin’s inn and nodded slowly.

“Your proposed designs for your inn seem feasible. However, I will have to charge you for this work, Erin. I am...unable to requisition supplies and aid so readily from my Hive at this time.”

“That’s fine! I wanted to pay you anyways. It wouldn’t be right otherwise.”

Erin smiled brightly at Klbkch.

“How much are we talking about here? I’ve got lots of gold coins.”

“I believe three hundred and twenty eight gold coins would be sufficient for this work.”

Erin paused. She stuck a finger in one ear and wiggled it around. But reality didn’t change, although she did find some earwax.

“Um. That’s...a lot.”

Klbkch nodded.

“Yes. Sadly, if we acquire useable wood from the forest of ah, ‘boom trees’, there is the matter of construction, hiring the Antinium, glass for the windows...”

“But *three hundred*—”

“Part of the cost—six silver coins out of every twenty—is given to Liscor under our treaty with the city. It is a non-negotiable tax.”

“That’s highway robbery!”

“No. That is our agreement. But it drives prices higher, as does a standing law that requires me to charge you for work outside of the city’s limits, as well as the necessity of guarding said Workers while they go about their tasks. To construct a third floor and expand your inn is a difficult task, Erin. Building a new home of quality would normally cost around two hundred gold coins in itself.”

Erin put her head in her hands. She didn’t have that money. She had a *lot* of money, but that...no. She stared at Klbkch.

“It’s the glass that’s expensive, isn’t it?”

He nodded.

“Each window costs approximately eight gold coins.”

Erin said a bad word. And then told Mrsha it was a bad word. The Gnoll nodded appreciatively as Erin sighed over the cost.

“What’s the problem?”

Someone came over to their table. Ryoka was gulping down water as Lyonette refilled her glass. She heard Erin’s woes out and barely listened to the issue of money before she nodded.

“I’ll pay for it, Erin. Go ahead and get everything built.”

Erin gaped at Ryoka.

“What? But Ryoka, it’s so *expensive*—”

The Runner shrugged carelessly. She sipped from her glass as Mrsha tried to leap onto her shoulder and failed. The Gnoll splatted onto the ground and went howling over to Lyonette, who scolded her about being reckless before cuddling her.

“I’m good for it. The Horns are paying me a bit more than that for doing the run to Invril and back. I’ll take it out of that and I’ll *still* have over a thousand gold coins to buy magical items with.”

“But—”

Ryoka flicked some sweat out of her eyes. She looked back at the door, where Pisces was waving her impatiently over.

“Erin, I really don’t *care*. Klbkch, I’ll give you the coins later, okay?”

She jogged back towards the door and vanished with a *pop* of dislocated air. Erin turned weakly back to Klbkch.

“I can pay some of it. Really.”

“We will negotiate the division of payment. But I will take Miss Ryoka’s word on credit. Her generosity is worth accepting, Erin.”

“Yeah, but I never give her anything back...”

Erin sighed. She felt guilty, but she wanted a better inn more. She also felt a bit hurt. True, Ryoka had all that money from running dangerously, but she didn’t treat it like it was, well, *important*.

Maybe it was because Ryoka used to be really rich? She said her father was some big shot politician guy and her mother also had an important job. Either way, it was done.

“I guess I’ll talk to Bird and see if he wants to be my guard. I think he will. And then I’ll have one guard! Do...do you think one is enough?”

Klbkch pondered the question before nodding.

“Safety is a relative term, but you are able to escape to Liscor and Celum quite quickly. Bird would no doubt be able to fend off any assailant if outnumbered or outmatched.”

“I didn’t mean—”

“It is his duty. If his death meant your survival, it would be a trade both he and I would be willing to make.”

Klbkch stared at Erin and she felt a cold pit open in her stomach. She didn’t reply, and the Antinium seemed to realize he’d made her uncomfortable. He switched subjects quickly.

“If assigning a group of Workers and Soldiers to your inn were permissible, I would do so. However, the contract between Liscor and my Hive—and my Queen’s own thoughts on the subject—do not allow for this course of action. If Bird agrees, I would have no issue allowing him to work at your inn on a semi-permanent basis.”

“Okay.”

He paused, looking at Erin. Klbkch clicked his mandibles and made a dry sound, clearing his throat.

“Well. We shall begin construction shortly. However, for the moment there is a...situation in the Hive and all Workers and Soldiers are needed. I shall send a team to begin work, but it may take more time if the need for bodies persists.”

“Oh? Is...something happening in the Hive?”

For some reason, Klbkch glanced at the other adventurers, the mages clustered around the door and Ceria, Yvlon, and Ksmvr talking at a table about their magical artifacts. He shook his head slowly.

“Nothing that need concern you, Erin. It is simply a busy time for us.”

He left quickly after that, heading back to his Hive. A bit unhappy, but more exhausted by all the planning, Erin mechanically got dinner ready. But she realized she didn’t have enough of the weird crunchy vegetable that was called for in her soup.

Yellats. Erin went to Celum rather than Liscor to get them. It was just as quick—quicker, since she didn’t have to go through the snow and she could get them at a shop. Erin made her purchase and headed back towards Octavia’s shop. But she took a detour at the Frenzied Hare.

“Hey Safry! How are you doing?”

“Erin!”

The [Barmaid] turned and smiled at Erin as the [Innkeeper] entered the bustling inn. Erin looked around for Miss Agnes, but the woman was nowhere to be seen. That was surprising, given how the inn was fairly full and both Maran and Safry were busy working with another woman Erin didn’t recognize.

“Wow. Busy evening crowd. Where’s Miss Agnes?”

“Oh, she’s out with her husband. Mister Agnes is feeling better, and business is good thanks to you. Miss Agnes hired another [Barmaid] and a [Cook]—she’s not around half as much as she used to be.”

Safry made a face as Maran rushed by with some drinks for a table whose occupants were crying out in thirst. Erin knew the [Barmaid] was

taking time to talk to her while the other two covered for her, so she talked fast and didn't beat about the bush.

"Hey Safry, I'm actually looking for some help. And I think you could give me good advice."

"Oh?"

The young woman—well, relatively young, since she was older than Erin—brushed sweat-dampened hair out of her eyes and smiled at Erin.

"What could I help you with?"

Erin smiled sheepishly. She liked Safry, and Maran. She'd worked with them for a week and they were hard working people. She felt a sort of kindred spirit with them.

"I'm actually sort of overworked right now in my own inn. I'm always cooking, cleaning, and so on. Lyonette helps a lot, but she's only one person, you know? So I was wondering...do you know any good [Barmaids] I could talk to? I'd like to hire at least two, maybe as many as four. I'm going to go to Liscor and ask Selys and Krshia as well, but I thought you might know of some people I could talk to."

Safry stared down at Erin, empty tray in hand. She looked around, and then to Erin's surprise, pulled up a chair in front of her table. She leaned closer to Erin, looking at the [Innkeeper] intently.

"You're looking for new [Barmaids]?"

There was a curious intensity to her tone. Erin nodded slowly.

"Yeah."

"In that case...what about me?"

"What?"

"Why not hire me?"

"*What?*"

Erin stared at Safry. Of all the responses she could have imagined—and she hadn't imagined any—this wasn't one of them. But Safry looked serious. And she was already turning, shouting out above the busy noise of the inn.

“Hey Maran! *Maran!*”

The other [Barmaid] came over, looking footsore and tired.

“Aw, Safry...we have work!”

“Just sit. Listen—Erin’s hiring [Barmaids].”

“What? Do you want to hire me?”

Maran immediately sat down next to Safry, leaving their third co-worker to struggle alone against the hordes. But the two older [Barmaids] were intent on Erin. And Erin couldn’t understand why.

“Why do you want to work at my inn? Maran, Safry—I thought you two liked it here!”

They exchanged glances. To Erin’s bewilderment, they both shook their heads.

“We don’t *like* it here, Erin. It’s a good job, don’t get me wrong, and I’d work it the rest of my life if I had to. I have to eat after all. But if you’re hiring...I’ve been to your inn before. It’s larger than Agnes’, and you’re easier to work with than she is. And I’d bet you’d pay better than she does, too!”

“You don’t like Miss Agnes?”

Erin had her own private beef with Agnes after Jasi, and just how the woman ran her inn in general, but she hadn’t ever expected the woman’s relationship with her workers to be one of those issues. But to her surprise, Safry and Maran were only too happy to badmouth the woman.

“Miss Agnes? She’s not half as good as you, Erin. She doesn’t run the inn like you can, she can’t cook...on bad days, she’ll scream at you for serving the customer the wrong order *she* gave you. Or dock your pay for taking a break when it’s not busy.”

“She doesn’t do that. Really?”

“Oh, she’s better when her husband’s well. And Mister Agnes is a steady fellow, but when she’s stressed it gets ugly. And, well, she’s just not sympathetic! I had a terrible cold—couldn’t take or afford a healing potion, you know how it is with sickness—and she told me if I didn’t work I’d be

fired, never mind that Maran was down with the same illness! I swear I gave my cold to two dozen folk, but I had to work.”

“She’s tight with her coin, too. We don’t get tips, Erin. I don’t know what world you come from—”

Erin jumped, but it was just an expression. Maran went on tiredly.

“—But folks don’t just leave extra coin for us. We rely on what Miss Agnes pays us, and that’s not much. True, it’s what most [Barmaids] get paid, but you’re a lot more generous than she is. You gave us a handful of coins each time after we’d worked our fingers off serving those crowds after the plays. Agnes would never do that.”

“I had no idea.”

It didn’t seem right to think less of Miss Agnes, not when Erin knew how the woman worked hard and tried to support her sick husband. But when she listened to Maran and Safry, Erin *had* to believe them. She couldn’t tell if they were lying, but she thought the things they were describing were the kinds of things Agnes might do. Like Ryoka had said, she wasn’t a bad woman.

Just not always a good one. And now Erin was faced with a problem, because she liked Maran and Safry. And she thought they might be a great help to Lyonette. However...

“If I hired you two, what would Miss Agnes do? I couldn’t do that, girls.”

Safry made a face.

“What, Agnes? If you hire us she’ll find two other [Barmaids] like that.”

She snapped her fingers dismissively. Maran nodded.

“A lot of girls have a few levels in the class, and it’s not like we’re *rare*. Erin, we’re begging you. Hire us!”

“But if Miss Agnes is angry...”

“She’d never scream at *you*, Erin. She’s afraid of you.”

“What? No.”

“Yes!”

Both [Barmaids] chorused at the same time. Erin stared at them.

“Me? Really?”

Safry nodded.

“You’re a Level 20 [Innkeeper] at least, right? Agnes is only Level 18, though she’s been working here for nearly a decade! It’s her husband who has all the cooking Skills. Ever since you came along, her inn’s been making ten times what it normally has!”

Maran chimed in.

“You also have that Skill—you know, where you get really scary? I swear, Miss Agnes nearly wet herself when you lectured her. She won’t kick up a fuss, Erin. Please?”

Erin put her head in her hands. This was too complex! She only wanted advice, but now she had to make a choice. When she looked up, Maran and Safry were still staring at her. Erin took a deep breath. Life was full of hard choices. And knowing what she did, Erin knew her decision already, though it might cause trouble. She looked at Safry.

“Okay, assuming I *were* to hire you...how much do you get paid now?”

The [Barmaids] smiled.

“What are *you* offering?”

Erin wavered. She didn’t know what [Barmaids] around here were paid, but she’d done her math, and figured out how much she could afford to pay.

“I was thinking...one silver coin and six copper coins per hour, and more if it’s a busy day? Bonuses if it’s a rush, obviously. Maybe a bit more? I dunno. What do you think?”

There was silence. Maran and Safry looked at each other. And then they looked at Erin. Safry spoke.

“How many [Barmaids] do you need? I have friends. And I could start tomorrow if you want.”

They leaned over the table, ignoring their coworker shouting that she needed help. Erin sat back in her chair and looked at the two [Barmaids].

She gulped.

It was dinner time, or rather, a bit past that when Ryoka finished the testing. She popped back into the air in Erin's inn, staggered, and clutched at her stomach. The teleportation made her feel as though she'd gone on a roller coaster ride at twice the normal speed. While inhaling paint fumes. Upside down.

"I think...I'm gonna be sick."

Pisces carefully stepped back as Ryoka covered her mouth. It wouldn't do to get his new robes dirty. True, he had the magical ones, but these were the unenchanted robes Ceria had gifted to him on Christmas. He would prefer to keep them clean.

Ryoka staggered over to a table and slumped onto it. Typhenous was sitting there, scribbling on a piece of parchment while Moore did math by tracing glowing numbers in the air. The two [Mages] concluded their calculations and looked up. They conferred with Pisces, and then presented their conclusion to Erin as she served everyone dinner.

"You're telling me you spent all day doing *maths*?"

Halrac looked outraged, especially since everyone else, including Revi, had been gathering information about the dungeon from the latest reports. But Typhenous refused to be shamed.

"The understanding of this door, my good Halrac, is a boon in itself. And our conclusion is stunning!"

"The door can send someone of Ryoka's general weight, give or take twenty pounds..."

Pisces flicked his fingers at Moore, and the half-Giant finished with a grin.

"...Five hundred and thirty six miles, given minimal change in altitude or magical ambience. The door would exhaust its magic after such a

teleport however, and require roughly eight point two hours to recharge fully.”

The [Mages] sat back as the other occupants of the room went still. Ceria whistled and Jelaqua took a long drink of mulled wine.

“All the way to Invril, huh? Even if it’s only once a day...that’s powerful.”

“Invril? Hah! Who’d want to go there? It’s full of annoying Humans!”

Heads turned as Relc waved his mug and shouted from his table. By his side, Olesm slouched down as the Humans glared at Relc. Both Drakes had come up from the city, but Relc was in a substantially worse mood than Olesm.

“Got something against Humans, have you?”

Seborn looked at Relc. The Drake nodded. He had a bruise on his arm, his scales faintly discolored. It was the first injury Erin could ever remember seeing Relc having, outside of when he’d fought Gazi.

“Sure do, fish guy! I had to break up four brawls of adventurers today. *Four!* You Humans cause too much trouble! At least when Drakes fight, they break it up when the Watch comes. But noooo...you Humans always fight back!”

“Probably because they’re not used to [Guardsmen] who are actually competent. Most of the ones in the northern cities are barrel-scrappings, not fit to be Bronze-rank adventurers.”

Revi spoke up from her table, eliciting a glare from Halrac and Ulrien and putting her squarely in the ‘not Human’ camp in the room. Erin watched the arguments with half an eye, although she thought it wouldn’t come to actual violence, especially when Lyonette circulated with another tray of drinks. She was getting good.

“Hey Erin, about what I was going to tell you...”

Olesm caught Erin as she was serving tonight’s dish, a spicy vegetable soup, mixed with some rather wonderful fried dino-bird that Bird had shot the other day. Erin slid into a seat as Olesm talked excitedly.

“I was sending some copies of your chess game around, and I had a lengthy correspondence with a famous [Strategist] from one of the Walled Cities! Well, I say famous...he’s not exactly the most shiny scale around, but he’s well-known and guess what? He wants to come *here* and play a game of chess with you, Erin! Here!”

“What? No way!”

“Yeah! I told him—well, I told him I’d ask you, but do you think—”

“I’d love to! Anytime! But wait, I barely have time to play...and I haven’t in such a long time! I’m rusty! Quick, let’s play a game.”

Erin and Olesm fussed over a chess board while Ryoka wandered over to a corner of the inn. She’d spotted someone fly in at some point, and sure enough, Ivolethe was eating an egg while perched on Mrsha’s head.

Just an egg. She’d cracked part of the bottom and was sucking the insides out. There was something disgusting about the tiny faerie eating that way, and Ryoka didn’t look too closely as she squatted down. Mrsha immediately moved over to sit next to Ryoka as the girl spoke to Ivolethe.

“Where have you been, then?”

Ivolethe licked some yolk off of her arm and looked archly at Ryoka.

“Away. I do not hover about ye all the time, Ryoka Griffin.”

“Fine, be obstinate. I just wanted to say that Mrsha and I—yes, you, Mrsha—are going to visit a friend in a day or two. She lives on a farm.”

“Ah, friendship.”

Ryoka waited for Ivolethe to say something biting, but the faerie just paused. Ryoka looked at her.

“You down for a visit, or will you be going somewhere else?”

Ivolethe shook her head.

“I will come. And it is good you will be going away for a day or two. I think it is time I taught you something. The winter will end soon, Ryoka. And when it does, so too shall we part.”

“Oh. Right.”

Ryoka hadn't been thinking about that. Rather deliberately. She stared at Ivolethe.

“You mean you think you can teach me magic? We haven't gotten around to it. And I didn't really manage to learn much when you tried before. But you think I can really learn how to run like the wind?”

The faerie was silent as she tossed the empty egg over her shoulder. It flew surprisingly far and high and bounced off of Ksmvr's head.

“I do not know. But I think...”

Ryoka watched Ivolethe carefully.

“Yes?”

The faerie nodded slowly. She smiled wickedly.

“Yes, I think it will be entertaining for *me*.”

She grinned at Ryoka, and the young woman bared her teeth in reply.

Across the inn, as Ksmvr stared at the eggshell and wondered aloud where it had come from, and then promptly asked Pisces to explain, Erin sat with Olesm and talked about her door.

“It's so cool! Ryoka says she could take a portal-door-thingy to Invisil and then I could go there and back any time I wanted! Okay, I could only go like once a day and then come back, but if I bought a mana potion or

something...Pisces says he could fuel the door with his own mana to make it charge faster!”

Olesm was sweating over the chess board, tail lashing furiously. Relc looked bored as he watched them play.

“Invrisil. Hah. Why’s everyone want to go there?”

“Well, Ryoka knows some people there and it sounds really cool. It’s one of the biggest cities on the continent!”

“One of the biggest *Human* cities.”

Relc folded his arms. Erin looked at him as she took one of Olesm’s knights and he covered his face in despair.

“What’s wrong with that? I want to go to a cool city. So what if it’s Human?”

Olesm looked up.

“But you don’t have to. You could go to one of the biggest Human cities on the continent...or a Drake city. You could reach one of the Walled Cities from here, Erin.”

“Yeah!”

Relc pounded a fist on the table, and then held out for Olesm to gingerly tap.

“Scales over skin! Whoops, sorry, Erin. Why not Drakes? Give us a chance!”

“Really? A Walled City?”

Erin had never gone south from Liscor. Neither had Ryoka. She had no idea what was south of Liscor, what things looked like. Ryoka had said she’d gone to a mountainous place, a forest, the Blood Fields...but never a city.

“The Walled Cities are amazing, Erin. I think you’d love to visit. Why not try and get a teleporting door there? I’m sure a lot of people from Liscor would pay good money to travel back and forth as well.”

Relc was nodding as Olesm spoke. Then he sat up, scratching at the spines on his head.

“Home, huh? That reminds me, what with this dungeon thing...I was thinking about it after that stupid Gazi kicked my tail a while back. But I really need to get my spear back.”

Olesm and Erin looked at Relc. Erin pointed silently to the spear the Drake had leaned against the wall near his table. Relc waved his tail at it dismissively.

“Not *that*. That’s just an ordinary spear, Erin! I mean my *spear*, my enchanted spear! I had it back when I was a [Sergeant] in army. But I had to leave it when I left. Stupid rules...but I think I need it to handle all these monsters and stupid Human adventurers.”

He glanced across the room at Ryoka, who was tossing Mrsha up and catching her, much to the Gnoll’s delight. He nodded at her and spoke conspiratorially to Erin.

“Think your runner friend could go to one of the Walled Cities for me, Erin? For maybe a discount? I need to send a message to the army.”

“Which army?”

“Liscor’s! Duh.”

Relc snorted.

“They’re fighting around one of the Walled Cities, last I heard. Well, they’re always fighting. I don’t know where they are exactly, but I bet anyone could tell your Runner friend. She looks familiar, by the way. Have I met her before? Ah, well, you Humans...anyways. It would only take like...a week or two? She’d be back in no time, I bet, especially if you give her one of those teleporting things.”

Erin stared at him. Olesm stared at him. Relc looked around innocently.

“One week? Come on. It’s not like it would take *months*. No? Fine. I guess I’ll go bug Hawk.”

The last visitor to the inn dropped by long after Mrsha had figured out how to throw up in midair and Ryoka had learned why tossing children and engaging in vigorous exercise around dinner time was a bad idea. Bird wandered into the inn and was immediately accosted by Erin.

“Bird! Guard! Bird House! I pay, you shoot! Birds! Bird!”

It took a while for him to understand what Erin was getting at, but when he realized what Erin was suggesting, Bird was ecstatic.

“I am ecstatic. Is that the word?”

“Yes! Oh, Bird, it’ll be great! You can have your own room, you can shoot birds, I can cook birds, Mrsha and Lyonette can be safe and you can stop her from running off without supervision—”

Mrsha, recovered and eating more food, gave Bird a wary look. He gave the Gnoll cub an even warier look, but nodded at Erin.

“Revalantor Klbkch has informed me of my duties. I would be happy to accept.”

Erin smiled at him.

“That’s great. Everything’s so great! Oh, by the way, is Pawn around? I heard he was trying to talk to me earlier, but I didn’t get a chance to see him. What did he want?”

Bird looked confused. He scratched his head, and then remembered. He replied cheerfully.

“Ah yes. I remember now. Pawn was to be assigned to combat duty with the group of Soldiers under his command today. He wished to speak with Erin and talk with her in case he perished later.”

It was like a spell. Everyone that heard Bird went instantly silent. Only Relc and the Halfseekers across the room hadn’t heard. Relc was laughing loudly at Jelaqua and challenging her to a drinking match when he realized the room had gone still. He turned and looked at Bird as Erin put a hand over her mouth. Bird looked confused as he stared around. He shrugged.

“What? He said it was only a possibility.”

4.13 L

Once upon a time there was a Worker. He had no name. He had no future. He had been born to work, and he knew he would die. If not today, then tomorrow.

He would die while working. A chance fall from the top of a building while carrying lumber might be his end, or perhaps in a freak monster attack. He might die when fighting to defend his Hive, or if a tunnel collapsed due to an earthquake or flood.

And if he survived that, he would die when he grew old. When he grew slower he would be given jobs fitting his station. But at some point he would be too slow, too weary. And then he would walk into the jaws of a monster, or curl up and stop breathing. That was what the Worker knew.

And he didn't mind. Because all routes led to death in the end, he did not worry about his fate. He was part of his Hive. If his Queen could live a fraction of a second longer, or his Hive prosper by the sum of one more copper coin, he would die fulfilled.

So he thought. And then one day, he met a girl named Erin Solstice. And she asked him if he had a name. The question had broken him into pieces. A simple question, but one that asked the Worker things he had never thought of, things he had no answers for.

He might have fallen. He might have become an Aberration. But he did not. He found a name in despair and found something else to live for besides his Queen. He found he was no longer a Worker, and he realized he was afraid of dying. He chose a name.

That was then. Now Pawn was something else. Not just a [Tactician] or [Carpenter] or [Butcher], but something that defined him. He had a class that was unique to him, something no one else had. He was an [Acolyte]. The first of his kind.

He was also a leader. It was not the same as [Tactician], no. For a [Tactician] only thought of the world in terms of loss and gain. They could command, but their Skills and nature did not inspire.

Pawn led Soldiers, the huge, silent guardians of the Hive. He had hundreds of them under his command, each one a killing machine. They didn't have hands. Their fists were designed for murder, for tearing and pounding force, not to hold things. They had less future than that of a Worker, for they would live and die in their Hive, fighting against threats with their short lifespans.

They were fierce, loyal, unwavering. Pawn did not deserve to command one of them, but he had no choice. He had been given a position of power, so Pawn had learned to lead. He had lives of Soldiers under his authority, and he had unwillingly accepted the trust they had placed in him. He was no true general, no gifted visionary, but he had a duty. So Pawn learned. He learned what to say when he held a dying Soldier in his arms.

And he learned how to give them hope. Because that was what the Antinium needed. Hope. A dream. Faith that there was something worth dying for. The Hive wasn't enough. Not at all. The Queen wasn't enough. What they needed was light.

So Pawn took the Soldiers who had lived their lives in darkness. He took them out of the Hive. And showed them the sky.

A few desultory snowflakes drifted down from grey skies above Liscor. A cold wind blew. Not a fell wind, or a chill wind—just cold. It wasn't a wind that could scourge flesh or scale from bone or freeze extremities in an instant. It was just cold. And unpleasant. The Drakes and Gnolls and Humans walking down the street moved quickly to be out of the wind and weather. They were sick of winter, and wanted it to be over already.

But the Antinium marching down the streets stared up at the sky and marveled. The Soldiers walked with uniform alertness behind Pawn, drawing heads and clearing the street as they marched down it. Drakes and Gnolls alike got out of the way, eyeing the Soldiers a bit warily, but without fear.

The Humans were less circumspect. Twice already, Pawn had seen a group of Humans scream and run, or reach for their weapons. Both times he had resolved the situation, but the Humans made him uneasy. He couldn't predict how they'd act.

The Drakes and Gnolls on the other hand, the citizens of Liscor, were easier. They just watched the Antinium warily, but the Soldiers Pawn led through the streets towards the eastern gates were accepted by now. Perhaps even liked?

No. No, not liked. Pawn sighed as he watched one of the Soldiers stare up at a cloud and then snap his head down and keep walking. It was a good sign. The Soldiers were too careful to stop paying attention, but these new ones had never seen the sky, let alone *snow* or people. Pawn knew they were staring while pretending not to. And he didn't mind. They would have a chance to stare as long as they liked today.

"Left here."

He indicated a street, and the Soldiers instantly filed after him, surprising a family of Gnolls. They backed away, but Pawn immediately halted to let them move past the Antinium.

"Hrr. Thank you."

The father—or mother—bowed her head to Pawn and he inclined his. The Gnolls stepped quickly around the Soldiers, half of whom stared at the furry Gnolls. And the Gnolls stared back. One of the three children of the family of five, the youngest, sniffed at a Soldier's leg and then hurried away as his parent snapped at him. It was another good sign, Pawn decided.

"Resume marching. Be careful of pedestrians."

Pawn began walking and his Soldiers immediately fell into step behind him. The Antinium marched down the street, pausing to let a wagon go past as the [Driver] stared down at the Antinium. He had no words for Pawn or the Soldiers, but that was good too.

Because it meant Liscor was getting used to Pawn's daily patrols.

At first, Pawn had encountered fear, suspicion, and downright hostility as he'd brought his group of Soldiers through the streets and out the gates. Despite Watch Captain Zevra and Klbkch assuring the residents of Liscor

that these Antinium were not dangerous, they had feared Pawn and his group almost as much as the rumors of Goblin armies or Rock Crabs.

At first. But each day, Pawn had come back, his Soldiers carrying dead Shield Spiders, Corusdeer carcasses, and other proof of their victories against the dangerous creatures roaming around Liscor. That was all they did. They went out, patrolled the landscape, and came back with spoils that were turned into meat for [Butchers], armor for [Blacksmiths], ingredients for [Alchemists], and so on.

And the city had accepted them. Slowly, but surely, the people had realized that Pawn's group of Soldiers were there to help. They had already known Klbkch, the Antinium with a name. He was recognized as a reliable, if odd, Senior Guardsman, and, it was said, the only person who could put up with Relc or survive his escapades. So instead of people fleeing the Antinium when they appeared or screaming for the Watch, they just watched.

And then Pawn had begun painting his Soldiers, or rather, letting them paint themselves. It was their identity, and perhaps the single greatest idea Pawn had ever had. Perhaps the greatest idea any Worker had ever had, come to that. Because the Soldiers could not speak. They could not name themselves and Pawn had agonized over that fact. How could they be remembered without an identity, especially because they all looked the same, even to Pawn?

With paint. That was how. The paint was thick, water-resistant, and Pawn had bought enough of it from Krshia to let the Soldiers reapply it to their armored carapaces whenever they wanted. And he had let them paint themselves. So each Soldier that walked behind Pawn stood out. And the people noticed.

"There they are again. Damn bugs."

A group of elderly Drakes sat at a table outside of one of the taverns, watching the Antinium wait for a wagon to be unloaded. They could move past, but Pawn didn't want to spook the Drakes and Gnolls who were working. They were already moving double-time to get out of the Soldiers' way.

In the meantime, the Drakes who'd taken issue with the Soldiers talked, and Pawn listened to them complain. They were old. Their scales were discolored in places by age and faded by time. These old Drakes often sat outside, Pawn knew. They seemed unaffected by the cold, or perhaps it was because they sipped spicy alcoholic beverages in the morning. They always had something to say about the Soldiers, too.

"Every day that Worker brings them this way. Now they're blocking my view of the street too. Ruins my morning."

"What morning? You barely wake up before noon."

"Shut up, Shadowspine. I rise at the crack of dawn—"

"*Hah!*"

"—at the *crack* of dawn I say, and if I have to crane my neck every time a band of those black giants passes by—"

"You barely turn your head when your grandchildren come by. You're just sore because I won five silver from you last night over dice."

"It was a bad toss! You barely rattled the dice around, you cheating—"

Two of the Drakes sitting at the table began arguing and throwing things at each other. They bickered loudly as Pawn passed by. But another of the Drakes sitting at the table, an old female Drake with grey-green scales peered intently at the group of Soldiers.

"There he is. See?"

"What?"

The two arguing male Drakes turned their heads. The female Drake smiled.

"The one with yellow paint. See? I saw him yesterday."

Pawn didn't have to look to know which Soldier she was talking about. One of the Soldiers marching behind him had yellow splatters of paint all over his carapace, as if someone had thrown globs of paint at him. In fact, that was exactly what had happened.

The old Drakes stared at the Soldier in question. One of them, the alleged cheater, coughed and grumbled.

“So? He looks silly. What did that one do, trip and knock paint all over himself?”

“Hush.”

The other Drake turned and flicked her tail, smacking the speaker in the chest with her tail. Pawn was impressed. Drakes had a good amount of control over their tails, but this old Drake seemed quite adept with hers.

“I like him.”

“Pah! That’s all you know, Shivertail.”

The old Drake that apparently woke up at the crack of dawn cast his eyes across the group of Soldiers. He pointed.

“There! That one’s far better.”

Every head in the group of Drakes turned to stare at the individual the Drake had pointed at. His chest and back was bare, but his arms and legs had been painted with purple slashes of color running from his shoulder down to his legs.

“Now *that’s* war paint.”

“Bah. What about that one?”

The cheating Drake pointed and Pawn saw he was looking at a Soldier who’d drawn a pair of eyes on his shoulders. It was unsettling how they seemed to stare at anyone the Soldier faced. But the elderly Drake seemed to approve.

“That’s proper art, that is. If you two knew anything about color, you’d be admiring him, or the one with the bird on his face.”

“Is that what it is? Who paints their face? That’s plain odd.”

“Bah. When I was a young [Soldier]—”

“Here we go again.”

“*Silence!* When *I* fought in the army as part of the *elite scouting division* —”

“You mean, glorified rangers?”

“—we hunted in groups, wearing war paint to demoralize the enemy! Anyone who saw our colors fled in fear or begged for their lives—”

“Didn’t you lot get routed by a single Gnoll tribe?”

“They had the terrain advantage! But mark me, if we’d been fighting on neutral ground—”

The wagon rumbled out of the way and Pawn continued marching. The arguing Drakes’ voices faded into the background noise, but Pawn’s smile did not.

Identity. Each of his Soldiers had it now. It wasn’t just elderly Drake grandmothers who watched out for a particular Soldier. Some of the other citizens noticed when a particular Soldier went past. It was like a game. The Antinium had been faceless and identical for so long that now there was a way to tell them apart, people were beginning to pay attention.

The Antinium group left the city, walking past the [Guardsmen] who watched the group with no visible signs of wariness. Pawn looked around and saw snow-covered hilltops, and a distinct lack of detail. So he pointed in a random direction, towards a mountain peak that looked somewhat inviting.

“We shall patrol in this direction. At a leisurely pace. Follow me.”

He began to walk. Not march, but walk. The Soldiers nearly ran Pawn over before they realized how slow he was moving. Over half of this group hadn’t ever been outside, and so they didn’t know how the patrol went.

Pawn proceeded up a hill, down a hill, and then around a hill because he was getting bored of walking up the incline. He set a pace slow enough that the Soldiers could get their fill of staring. Because they would stare, Pawn knew. They would stare at the snow, the sky, and watch a bird until it died of boredom if he let them. It wasn’t because the Soldiers were that simple, either. It was because they had never *seen* any of these things, and so the experience was precious and wonderful to them.

In that, Pawn envied the Soldiers. They could find so much meaning in a blade of grass. Too much, in fact. Pawn had learned to start the Soldiers off slow, get them out of the city and patrolling the boring landscape around Liscor for a few hours. Because that was all the stimulation the Soldiers

could handle. Only after that would Pawn work them up to getting back in the city, staring at flowers, fire, and eating.

Food was one of the highlights of the day for Pawn, and probably the most important experience he could give the Soldiers. Instead of the horrible paste they ate, each one would get a meal courtesy of Lyonette, or more recently, Erin.

Erin. Pawn stopped and let the Soldiers covertly bend down and feel at the snow. Erin was back. He hadn't had time to talk to her, but she was back. That filled Pawn with countless emotions, relief being first among them. She was back.

He hadn't gotten a chance to speak with her much, of course. Erin was always busy and so was Pawn. He didn't like to bother her. Pawn had his life and Erin...was surely too busy to always be looking after him. He had Soldiers to lead now. And not only that...

He had a faith, as well. Pawn was an [Acolyte]. He could pray. He had no god, but he believed in heaven. And it was that faith that gave him a class and Skills no one else had.

Once, Pawn had told the Soldiers about heaven. They had believed in it like he had, and killed themselves to go there, rather than stay. But that was not the way. Pawn had known it. So he had told the Soldiers to stay, to build a heaven for the Antinium while they lived. Because there was no heaven for the Antinium. There was a god—one for the religion of Christianity, for Humans, that Erin had told Pawn about. But none for the Antinium.

So Pawn would make a heaven for his people, for the Workers and Soldiers. He just had to figure out how.

After a while, Pawn began walking again. The Soldiers fell in. He walked over a hill, down a hill, into a Shield Spider's nest—

The Soldiers jumped in after Pawn and he got out with only a bite on his arm, barely fracturing his carapace. Pawn shakily climbed out of the pit as the Soldiers began smashing the Shield Spiders to bits.

“Ah...very good. Thank you.”

There was danger out in the area around Liscor. Not a patrol went by when Pawn didn't have his Soldiers fight something or other. But not a

single Soldier had died on these patrols, not one. Pawn was proud of that. The Rock Crabs, the fearsome scuttling giant boulders, were no match for the Antinium en masse. The Soldiers would just hold the Rock Crab's shell down and break through the top with brute force, killing the surprised crustacean from above while it was pinned down.

Soldiers didn't fight fair. They didn't fight dirty either. They just fought. The Soldiers probably would have been astounded to learn there *was* a way to fight fair. They had been born to kill, and they did that quite efficiently.

Pawn watched as a Soldier *kicked* a Shield Spider into the air. The armored spiders were a considerable threat, worthy of a Silver-rank team or more dangerous in larger nests. Their armor could resist sword cuts, and they had terribly dangerous bites. A normal warrior would be hard-pressed to kill one, even with a mace or axe.

But the Soldiers were strong. One picked up a Shield Spider and held it as it struggled. Another Soldier hit it repeatedly as the other Soldier held it until the Spider's center burst. Pawn looked away. Then he looked back sharply as something strange happened.

A Soldier had been striking down at a particularly large and aggressive Shield Spider. It had bitten into his legs, sending trickles of green blood out of the wounds. Pawn would have ordered someone to help, but the Soldier suddenly paused as the Shield Spider reared up, trying to bite at his face. The Soldier seemed to hesitate—and then one of his hands *blurred*.

It was an uppercut, but at a speed that nearly escaped Pawn's vision. The blow caught the Shield Spider as it was rearing and knocked its head off. Literally. Pawn flinched as bits flew out of the pit. The headless Shield Spider collapsed and the Soldier stared at his fist.

Every other Soldier in the pit stared too. Pawn stared as well. He jumped down into the pit and walked over to the Soldier, who flinched.

"Was that a Skill?"

The Soldier stood at attention, silent. Pawn stared at him. This Soldier was the one with the yellow splatters the Drake grandmother had found so interesting. He had patrolled with Pawn several times before.

"Did you use a Skill?"

The Soldier stared down at Pawn. The Worker couldn't read what was behind his eyes, but he had grown used to the Soldiers by now. He thought the Soldier seemed...nervous? Could Soldiers feel fear? But then the Soldier nodded hesitantly.

“A Skill.”

Pawn exhaled, clicking his mandibles together. One of his Soldiers had learned an activated Skill? That meant...they had leveled up! Pawn knew the Soldiers might, but to realize it now...

“What level are you? No—what class? Is there a way to tell? Ah, but... you do not know how to write and your fingers...”

Pawn stared at the Soldier as he looked down at Pawn. He seemed nervous for all that he was bigger, and stronger than Pawn. The Worker nodded at last, and the Soldier flinched as Pawn looked at him.

“Good work.”

All of the Soldiers stared. Pawn looked around.

“If you have Skills, do not hesitate to use them. But please do not risk yourselves.”

He pointed to the Soldier's lacerated legs.

“We will stop the bleeding before continuing. The rest of you, clean up the corpses. We will collect them on the way back.”

The Soldiers paused, and then got to work. Pawn had the Soldier with yellow splatters sit and stopped the bleeding with cold snow and some strips of linen he'd purchased with his limited supply of coin. The Worker apologized, because he hadn't been allowed to use the Hive's supply of healing potions on Soldiers.

But he cared. And that was why the Soldiers followed him. Because even if Pawn didn't know it, he had given them a purpose. He had given them identity, shown them the sky. He had given them something to believe in, and so they followed him. Each one would die for him.

But Pawn didn't know that. All he knew was that it was another day. Another fine day, where none of his Soldiers had died. And it would have

been a fine day tomorrow, where he did the same thing again. It would have been, but Klbkch summoned him the instant he returned to the Hive.

“Combat duty?”

Pawn sat in Klbkch’s small office, a dirt room filled with a table and two chairs. And a coatrack which held no coats. Only a single scarf. Klbkch looked up from his desk where he was busy writing something down and nodded briefly.

“That is correct. Do I need to repeat myself?”

“No. It is just that—why me? Why now?”

Pawn stared at Klbkch as the other Antinium clicked his mandibles sharply together in irritation and pushed his papers aside. Pawn felt nervous as Klbkch regarded him over the desk.

He was afraid of the other Antinium. Klbkch may have been the Revalantor of the Hive, and the former Prognugator, both a unique role for the one individual Antinium who directly served the Queen and enforced her will, but Pawn knew his blades had slain more of his fellow Workers than any lone monster.

For that was the duty of a Prognugator. To lead the Antinium in battle, to oversee the Hive while the Queen was busy, and to kill Aberrations. In theory that meant individuals like Pawn, if he turned out to be useless or worse, a traitor to the Hive.

Pawn could never forget that when he was around Klbkch. The Revalantor studied Pawn, and then nodded shortly as if he’d made a decision.

“I require your group of Soldiers to fight today for two reasons. Firstly, I wish to test whether any of them have indeed gained levels as a result of your leadership.”

Pawn nodded as his heart sank. That was the reason Klbkch had assigned the surviving Soldiers to him in the first place, to make them

stronger. Pawn knew that, but it was too *soon*! They'd barely been with him for a week, and now they might die? But Klbkch wasn't done. He stared up at the ceiling for a moment before looking at Pawn.

"Ordinarily, I would give your unit another month before committing you to a far less-dangerous assignment to test your capabilities. However... the second reason is that we are in need of every Soldier in the Hive at this moment, Pawn. Each and every one, regardless of their worth. I recalled Anand and his group of Soldiers and Workers to the Hive two days ago, but they were not enough. Your Soldiers will fight and many may die. But they are needed to hold the line. If they cannot hold, we may be overrun."

"What?"

Pawn felt stunned. Overrun? How could the Hive be overrun? Klbkch studied Pawn and shook his head.

"Ah, now I realize you are not informed about matters within the Hive. Belgrade and Anand know, but they have not spoken to you of this matter, have they?"

"No. I have not spoken to them for several days now."

Pawn hesitated. He hadn't seen Belgrade or Anand at all, actually. Klbkch nodded.

"They have been working without rest to defend the Hive. Now I understand. I will inform you of the situation, so you may understand why your Soldiers are needed, Pawn. I would not do so for Belgrade or Anand except in a tactical sense, but you are like Relc."

"I am?"

"You are. You ask superfluous questions. Now listen. You are aware our Hive has battled monsters from the dungeon underneath Liscor, correct?"

"Yes. We always have been."

For as long as Pawn had lived, the Hive had fended off the incursion of monsters from the dungeon. There were many, many routes from the dungeon to the Hive, many tunnels dug by hungry monsters or by the Antinium. They had to be guarded against attack, which is why Soldiers fought almost daily. But the Hive had always pushed back every attack,

from Shield Spiders to Pickstriker fungi, and Crypt Worms and the undead. What had changed?

“We have always sought to defend ourselves from monsters within the dungeon. It has been a difficult task at times, but we have defeated every incursion regardless of the cost of life. However, now that adventurers have entered the dungeon...it is waking up.”

“Waking up? It is sentient?”

Klbgch shook his head.

“That is a metaphorical statement. A non-Antinium expression. To clarify, the population of monsters is growing increasingly active in response to numerous food sources. Thus, the amount of attacks on our Hive has doubled or even tripled in number. For the first time, the Hive is losing more Workers and Soldiers in battle than it produces. We are struggling to increase reproduction while holding the line.”

“I did not know.”

Pawn knew Soldiers and Workers died each day. But he hadn't noticed more empty spaces or fewer bodies. There were so many Antinium in the Hive, how could you tell? Klbgch tapped the desk slowly.

“You were not meant to know. Nor will you tell anyone of our weakness, including Erin. Is that understood?”

He waited until Pawn had nodded to go on.

“We are capable of resolving this issue—in time. Workers are attempting to repair breached tunnels and create a second layer of fortifications. That is not the issue. The issue is that while Anand and Belgrade have successfully held back every monster attack—with far less loss of life due to their Skills—the latest skirmish created an event where Anand was wounded.”

Something *twisted* in Pawn. He hadn't known.

“Is he dead?”

“No. But he is unable to lead, and Belgrade is unable to command alone. I must fulfill my duties as Senior Guardsman for a set period of each day, and rest at other times. I cannot apply for leave and alert the city of the

Hive's weakness at this moment. Thus, you must fulfill the void Anand has left."

Pawn absorbed all this slowly. He had to fight? With his Soldiers? But—they had paint. They had identity. They were...his. And he had to tell them to die?

Perhaps Klbkch saw his indecision, because the Revalantor spoke sharply.

"You will select one hundred of your Soldiers to do battle. So long as you hold your position, there will be no issue. Belgrade is able to handle the battle as a whole. But you will not retreat unless ordered to, understood?"

Pawn wanted to object, but he knew it was pointless. Instead he asked the other question on his mind.

"What about the other Antinium? The visitors? Will they not fight to defend the Hive?"

Klbkch paused. Pawn had seen the other Antinium, and he remembered the one called Xrn, the Small Queen. She had been radiant. And she knew magic! He had never heard of someone like her, but Pawn was equally in awe of the Antinium with wings, and the ones that wore armor, or seemed to slide from shadow to shadow. Surely they could fight?

But the Revalantor just shook his head.

"They are guests of the Hive. If they wish to participate in battle, they are free to do so. But to request aid is...not a course of action which my Queen and I wish to undertake. No, we will fight back the monsters alone. You have your orders Pawn. Report to Belgrade tomorrow at noon. Now, leave."

Pawn left. He didn't want to, but he dared not defy Klbkch. Not the Slayer. And Pawn knew he was right. If the Hive was in danger, he and his Soldiers had a duty. They *had* to fight.

But Pawn didn't have to like it. He immediately began walking down through the tunnels of his Hive, following the flow of Workers, searching for Belgrade.

He found the Antinium in the chess room. That was where other Workers played chess. They had no names. They were still not Individual,

despite having leveled up in the [Tactician] class. Klbkch and Pawn had agreed the Workers were missing a key element to gain individuality.

Erin. Probably.

But Belgrade and Anand still loved to play. They always hung about in this room when not on duty.

Belgrade was not playing when Pawn found him. He was sitting by himself, in a corner, and the other Workers were sitting as far away from him as possible, glancing at him. Belgrade was hunched into a ball, clasping his four arms around himself in a pose Pawn had never seen before.

He was shaking.

“Belgrade. What is wrong? Are you sick? Are you injured?”

Pawn knelt beside his friend. Belgrade turned his head towards Pawn, and his mandibles clacked together soundlessly. When he spoke, his voice was taut, strained.

“Pawn? I—I cannot. Revalantor Klbkch says I must fulfill Anand’s role and my own, but there are too many, Pawn! I cannot counter all these attacks, and if they overrun the entrenched fortifications—”

“Belgrade. Listen to me—”

“I cannot do it alone, Pawn! Each time I send Soldiers and Workers out, they are killed, Pawn! There are too many this time. Shield Spiders, hundreds of them keep pouring out of the tunnels! And there are suits of armor that ten Soldiers cannot bring down, and the Crypt Worms! They are reanimating our dead, Pawn, *our dead*. Anand and I could fight them together, but by myself—”

“Belgrade.”

Pawn reached for Belgrade and held his shoulder. Erin had done that to him, once. The other Antinium was shaking, but it grew less as Pawn held him firmly. He looked into Belgrade’s eyes as Erin had once done. Pawn wondered if he should sing.

“I do not know how to sing.”

“What?”

“Nothing. Belgrade, listen to me. You will not be alone tomorrow. I will be participating in battle as well, with my unit of Soldiers.”

“You?”

Belgrade stared at Pawn. Rather than finding reassurance in this knowledge as Pawn had hoped, he looked horrified.

“Who gave you this order?”

“Klbkch.”

“No. I must speak to him.”

Belgrade struggled to get up, but Pawn held him down.

“I see the necessity of this order now, Belgrade. I will fight.”

The other [Tactician] shook his head.

“It is too dangerous, Pawn. You are not the same level of [Tactician] as I am. The fighting envelops the entire area—monsters will dig through the walls, or bypass defenses. You will not be safe.”

“You and Anand were not safe. I am needed. My Soldiers are of a higher level than the others, Belgrade. That is why Klbkch assigned them to my command.”

Belgrade hesitated, looking at Pawn with one of his multi-faceted eyes.

“Truly? That would be—but it is still—”

He broke off, thinking. Pawn could see the [Tactician] part of Belgrade analyzing Pawn’s statement, looking to see how it might help in the coming conflict. He nodded, heart pounding out of his chest, but forced the words out of his mandibles.

“Leave the most dangerous areas to my group of Soldiers, Belgrade. We will not retreat. And we...we will do our duty.”

There was nothing more to be said. Pawn was a Worker, and he commanded Soldiers. They had been created to fight, to protect the Hive, as had Belgrade. And now Pawn understood something else as well. If he did not fight, Belgrade might die. Or more Soldiers and Workers might die. It wasn’t a choice where his Soldiers would die or not die if Pawn refused to fight. If he did not fight with them, Antinium would die. If he *did* fight,

Antinium would still die. But perhaps if his Soldiers fought, less Antinium would die.

There was no good outcome. But there was only one choice that Pawn could take. And Belgrade saw it. He nodded. The shaking had stopped. Slowly, the [Tactician] got to his feet and placed his hand on Pawn's shoulder as the other Antinium had done for him.

"I must rest if I am to fight at peak efficiency. Pawn, you must promise me to stay behind your Soldiers. If you die...I would not know how to speak to Erin."

"I know."

Belgrade left the room. Pawn remained. He clenched his fist. Now he had no other choice. Not that he'd ever really had another option. He turned to go, to seek out Erin despite the late hour, when someone called out his name. Pawn turned, and saw another Antinium staring at him across the room.

"You are the Individual designated as Pawn, are you not?"

The other Antinium was not a part of Pawn's Hive. He could not be. No Antinium looked like him, not even Klbkch. This Antinium was as tall as a Soldier, and had the same build, but he had only two arms, and he carried a mace and shield at his side.

And he was wearing armor. It shone in the light, and in the eyes of the Workers who stared at him. Tersk, the Prognugator of the Armored Antinium was an armored giant, and he had a helmet which protected his head, which had no antennae.

"Prognugator Tersk."

Pawn bowed his head as Tersk strode forwards. Tersk nodded in reply. Pawn had not spoken to any of the special Antinium who had come to visit the Hive, although the others, Belgrade, Anand, Bird, and Garry had all had strange interviews with the other Prognugators.

"How may I help you, Prognugator Tersk?"

"I wish to speak with you, Individual Pawn. I had wished to make your acquaintance when I heard of your existence a few days ago, but I have not seen you about until now."

“Ah. I have been...busy.”

Tersk nodded.

“Yes. I understand you command a detachment of Soldiers. Tell me, Individual Pawn. How do you feel they would match up against a similar unit of Soldiers from my Hive?”

It was a military question, a question of tactics and analysis. Pawn stared at Tersk blankly and shrugged.

“I don’t know.”

The armored Prognugator paused. He seemed surprised by Pawn’s response.

“You don’t know? But you have levels in [Tactician].”

“Only a few. I have not fought, Prognugator Tersk. And I do not know the capabilities of your Soldiers.”

“Ah. I understand. I will signal my Soldiers to approach.”

Tersk turned his head and to Pawn’s surprise, took his mace and struck his shield with it, making a dull metallic beat that sounded like some sort of signal. And in less than a second, two Soldiers appeared, striding into the room and halting behind Tersk.

Why hadn’t he used Klbkch and Ksmvr’s inaudible way of signaling Antinium, like the Queen? Pawn’s eyes went to Tersk’s helmeted head. Oh. He didn’t have antennae.

“Here are two examples of my Hive for you, Pawn.”

Tersk indicated the two Soldiers, and Pawn noted that these Soldiers had a greatsword and a spear respectively. They stood completely still, staring ahead like Pawn’s Soldiers.

“We are the Armored Antinium, the sole Hive to use steel and metal to reinforce our bodies. We fight with weapons because they are more efficient, and allow for greater survivability of each individual in combat. We fight in formation, and are adept at battle above and below-ground. Now that you have analyzed these two Soldiers, tell me, what chance would your special unit have against them?”

“Well, there are two of them and I have over two hundred Soldiers under my command. I think we would win.”

Pawn’s reply made Tersk pause again.

“I was referring to an engagement of equal numbers.”

“Oh. In that case I don’t know.”

Pawn stared at Tersk, almost daring the Prognugator to ask another question as Tersk paused. He didn’t know why he was feeling hostile towards Tersk. Maybe it was because Tersk *wasn’t* fighting and Belgrade had been. Even Klbkch was leading the Antinium, when he wasn’t above-ground. But what had Tersk done for Pawn? According to Garry, all he did was wander around and ask questions. He had armor and a *mace*. He could be fighting!

“I understand your assessment capabilities are somewhat limited, Individual Pawn. I ask these questions to ascertain how your Hive’s capabilities match my own. It is a matter of strategic importance.”

“I have not heard of your Hive, Prognugator Tersk. But I am sure it is a capable one. However, I have never seen another Hive besides my own or other Antinium until recently.”

“Yes. Contact between the Hives is limited. That is a situation I feel must be rectified if we are to combine efforts.”

Tersk nodded repeatedly. He seemed so serious. Pawn felt a bit bad for being deliberately obtuse. But then Tersk turned to Pawn and began asking more questions.

“What is your class? What do you do besides lead Soldiers, Individual Pawn?”

Why did he keep calling Pawn that? The minute tolerance Pawn had felt evaporated. He answered shortly.

“I am an [Acolyte]. I pray.”

“An [Acolyte]?”

“Yes. Would you like me to repeat myself?”

Tersk paused, and his mandibles clicked together inside his helmet.

“I am unfamiliar with this class. I take it that it is unusual?”

“Yes.”

Perhaps unique. Why was Tersk asking all these questions? Pawn... didn't feel like talking at this moment. Even to a Prognugator. It was an insidious, rebellious thought, he knew, but Tersk wasn't *his* Prognugator. And Pawn hadn't cared for Ksmvr, his former Prognugator, either. Why did he have to obey anyone, for that matter? Why did he have to obey Klbkch?

Oh. Right. He had swords. And Tersk had a mace. And two large armored Soldiers following him. Pawn grudgingly continued to talk rather than walk away.

“And what is prayer?”

“It is believing in something. It is believing, and having faith that something is true.”

Tersk waited, but that was the only answer Pawn was going to give him. The Worker crossed his arms, and Tersk noted that.

“Ah. And is this prayer activity enjoyable?”

“Not really. Not all the time.”

Tersk paused.

“It is helpful in some way?”

“Sometimes.”

There was no way of knowing. Pawn had prayed the day Soldiers lay dying, clinging to life after trying to kill themselves. Had more survived because he had prayed while trying to keep them alive? Did a prayer do anything? Pawn asked those questions every day, but he still prayed. He prayed that there was a meaning to prayer itself.

“I see. In that case, perhaps you will instruct me in the method of this prayer activity at a later date. It sounds intriguing.”

That surprised Pawn.

“Why? I doubt it would be useful to you, Tersk.”

Tersk nodded, looking thoughtful.

“The utility of this activity does not concern me, so much as the value of entertainment derived from it. You see, the Prognugator class is meant to oversee, to learn. However, one of the failings of my station is the nature of boredom.”

“You get bored?”

Tersk paused, and seemed to grow a bit guarded.

“At times. I serve my Queen best when my mind is alert. To that end, I require mental stimulation. It is a careful balance of factors that contributes to my most efficacious state. But another question. You are assigned to combat the monsters attacking from Liscor’s dungeon tomorrow.”

“Yes I am.”

“How do you believe your detachment of Soldiers will fare—”

“No clue.”

The two Antinium stood in silence for a minute. Tersk stared at Pawn.

“Do you not wish to tell me your evaluation, Individual Pawn? If so, I must ask why—”

That was it. Pawn raised his voice slightly.

“I don’t *know*. I told you, I cannot make such judgments.”

“But surely, based on your previous experience—”

“I have never fought monsters from the dungeon.”

The Armored Antinium stopped.

“Oh. But surely you are aware of the dangers of the dungeon?”

“Of course I know. But I have never been assigned there myself.”

Tersk paused.

“Ah.”

How could Pawn not know? He knew Workers were assigned to construct defenses, shore up and fortify tunnels, all while Soldiers fought and died. He knew how many died each day. He could see the empty spot in the barracks. But he had never been there, never really thought about the

cost. They were all Antinium, and they died for the Hive. That was all. It hadn't really mattered so long as the Hive was fine, in Pawn's mind.

Until now.

Tersk looked at Pawn, calculating, and then turned his head to look around the chess room.

"I understand the effort of this room is to create more Individuals like Belgrade and Anand. That is a logical way of thinking. The monsters that attack from Liscor's dungeon are of a considerable threat, which surprised me given my understanding of this Hive's...capabilities."

"Did you fight on the front lines?"

Tersk shook his head.

"I did not. My safety is important to my Hive and I would not risk myself. However, Revalantor Pivr did participate in battle and was wounded. *Three* of the five warriors accompanying him were slain, and the heavy-combat variant he brought was heavily damaged in the fighting. He underestimated the monsters your Hive fights against."

For some reason, that really cheered Pawn up. He didn't like the buzzing Revalantor of the Flying Antinium, and suspected no one else did either. The thought that Pivr and his elite warriors couldn't do better than Soldiers from Pawn's Hive was...well, it wasn't a bad feeling.

"Revalantor Pivr's failure is instructional for us all."

Tersk nodded.

"Yes. I believe he is somewhat of a failure of the Prognugator class. Moreover, I would argue that he does not deserve the title of Revalantor either. He does not command the same presence as Revalantor Klbkch, nor does he possess half as much experience in battle as Klbkch the Slayer."

He spoke about Klbkch almost reverentially. Pawn tilted his head.

"You know of Klbkch?"

"Revalantor Klbkch? Of course. I was instructed to learn from the examples of my predecessors, and Klbkch the Slayer's exploits are notable within my own Hive's history. According to my Queen, Klbkch is the most stable and trustworthy of the three remaining Centenium."

Curious. Pawn only knew fragments about the Centenium, and Klbkch hadn't told him more than a few things. Like how all the current Antinium were based on the form of Galuc, the Builder. He realized Tersk might know more and pressed the Prognugator.

“What do you know of Prognugators, Tersk?”

The Armored Antinium tapped a hand on his armor, making a ringing sound as metal struck metal.

“I am familiar with my duties, and that my creation was an arduous task for my Queen. Prognugators require too many resources to justify the cost at the moment, hence my desire to remain alive to serve my Hive. However, I am aware this was not always the case.”

“Really?”

Tersk nodded.

“Before we came across the ocean, it was apparently a common practice to appoint multiple Prognugators per each Hive. As many as thirty in some cases, or so my Queen has told me.”

“*Thirty?*”

“Apparently. This was a time when we remained on Rhir. But my Queen has not spoken on that subject, and I am afraid that Revalantor Klbkch or Prognugator Xrn would know more than I. Ah, I had one more question for you, Individual Pawn.”

“What is it?”

This time Tersk visibly hesitated before he spoke.

“I have witnessed the Soldiers under your command. I noticed the markings on them, the paint markings. They are...striking. I wonder if such paints would allow for greater visual recognition on the battlefield. However, I do not understand why each Soldier is painted differently. Please explain that aspect to me, Individual Pawn.”

“They are important because they define the Soldiers, Tersk.”

The Armored Antinium waited.

“Only that? I thought there would be some greater meaning to the paint.”

Pawn nodded.

“That is everything. That is what makes the Antinium...Individual.”

“No. That is not what I understand Individuals to be. If paint were all that it took to create an Individual, why not paint every Antinium?”

“Because they need to do it themselves. It is a choice, Tersk. The Soldiers under my command chose their markings, chose to be Individual. That is what makes the paint so special.”

Tersk folded his arms, sounding testy as he replied.

“I do not understand. That seems illogical. Soldiers should allow themselves to be painted if it means they will become Individual and better serve the Hive.”

He really didn't understand. Pawn felt a hot bubble of anger bubbling up inside him. He had places to be! He'd spoken with Tersk so long, he was sure Erin was probably asleep by the time it would take to reach her. He stared at Tersk, unmarked by battle, striding around asking questions not understanding anything.

“You remind me of a former Prognugator I served, Prognugator Tersk. Prognugator Ksmvr did not understand what it meant to be Individual either.”

The words struck Tersk, and Pawn saw him straighten slightly.

“I understand Prognugator Ksmvr was expelled from the Hive for incompetence, Individual Pawn. I am not sure I appreciate the comparison.”

“I think it is apt.”

Tersk stared down at Pawn. He opened his mandibles slowly as he clenched his fists.

“It occurs to me, Individual Pawn, that your statements throughout this conversation have been deliberately inflammatory and unhelpful.”

Pawn nodded slowly.

“Yes. I believe they have been.”

Tersk clenched one hand and took a step towards Pawn. The Soldiers did likewise, and the other Workers quietly playing chess froze and stared at the Armored Antinium. Tersk spoke quietly.

“I am a Prognugator of the Hive. I am not your Prognugator, but I will be answered with full clarity. That is what Revalantor Klbkch promised me. Need I take the issue up with him?”

Pawn nearly laughed in Tersk’s face. If that was a threat, it was the worst one Pawn had ever heard. He spread two of his arms out.

“You wish to understand, Tersk? Then understand this.”

He pointed at Tersk. He didn’t poke the other Antinium, because Pawn was sure that if he did, the other two Soldiers would kill him. But he did shout.

“Neither of you can understand what it means to be a Worker or a Soldier! We are not just numbers, Tersk. We feel pain. We suffer. We despair. And we die. If we do not feel boredom, it is because we have never known respite. You cannot understand what makes us Individual.”

“The other Individual, Belgrade, froze up due to his fear. Is that the weakness of your new identity, Individual Pawn? The Prognugators do not bow to emotion.”

“Neither do we.”

Pawn spat the words at Tersk. He felt angry, angry because Tersk did not understand, because he *couldn’t*. How could this Antinium be a Prognugator, lead Soldiers and Workers like this?

“If you cannot understand Belgrade’s fear, then it is because you have never experienced failure. You do not feel the same danger. You wear armor. We have none. If you want to understand us, take off your armor and fight as we do, with your bare hands. I would tell you to ask your Soldiers, but they have no voice. That is a pity, or they might tell you all you are doing wrong.”

He turned and stormed away, despite Tersk shouting for him to stop and explain. Pawn left the chess room, and Tersk stood in the silence as Workers hunched over their chess boards. At last, the Armored Antinium looked over his shoulder at the two silent Soldiers.

“I do not comprehend that strange Individual Pawn. What am I doing wrong?”

They just stared at him and did not reply.

The next day, Pawn went to see Erin. She was not there. He waited, but before long he had to return to his Hive. It was time. One second he was in the Wandering Inn, speaking with Bird, asking him to tell Erin...to tell Erin...

And then he was in his Hive, facing his Soldiers. They were arrayed before him, a hundred, a little less than half of his entire command. They faced him, painted bodies standing tall, unflinching.

Pawn wished he felt half as confident as they looked. He walked slowly down their line, staring at each Soldier in turn, at their markings. They looked back at him, their leader.

Pawn had never felt like more of a fraud in his life. He had never felt like a fraud, in truth. He had been as true a Worker as any other, and confident in that knowledge. But a leader?

He was no leader. He didn't have the class. He didn't have the Skill, or the skill. He was not Zel Shivertail.

But he had to try. So Pawn squared his shoulders and spoke to the assembled Soldiers. His Soldiers.

“We are going into combat in twenty minutes.”

They looked at him. Not one Soldier moved. They had expected this. Perhaps they had known. They had ears...earholes, after all. Pawn nodded.

“You have fought before, I know. I have not. I believe I am unworthy of leading you.”

The Soldiers did stir at this. One of them paused, hesitated, and then shook his head. The other Soldiers looked at him, and then they all shook

their heads. Pawn stared. He felt like he wanted to cry, like he'd seen Erin do. But the Antinium could not cry.

Instead, he bowed his head and uttered a prayer.

"I am praying."

The Soldiers stopped shaking their heads. Pawn lowered his. He couldn't close his eyes, but he clasped his hands together.

"I am praying for us all. I pray that we will survive this, each one of us. I do not pray that we will not fight. We must fight. It is *right* that we were chosen to fight. Because we, all of you, and me, are capable. We aren't just fighting for ourselves, or to stay alive, but for the entire Hive."

He gestured at the Soldiers standing in front of him, solemn, each one an individual, marked with paint, given identity.

"You are my people. If one of you died, you could never be replaced. Ever. And yet...the unnamed Workers and Soldiers who die each day are my people too. I did not think of it that way before."

Pawn clenched his fist.

"I do now. Each day, Soldiers and Workers die. Sometimes only one or two. Other days, hundreds. Of late, too many have died. So we must fight. You are stronger than the average Soldier, you have levels. If we fight here, maybe a few less Soldiers and Workers will die. I think...I have to think that is worth it."

There was no reply. Pawn looked at his Soldiers. He spoke to them like Zel told him to. When you held a dying soldier in your arms, you lied to him. You told him it would be alright. Or you told him the truth. But when you spoke to soldiers before they were going to die, you told them nothing but the truth. Or you lied.

This time, Pawn told them the truth.

"We are going to fight. Some of you may die. I may die. I hope none of you will. After this, I will bring you to the Wandering Inn and we will all eat. But we must fight. If we do not, our comrades will die. Other Soldiers will die, other Workers. We are fighting for each other. Remember that."

He raised his hand, clenched it into a fist. Pawn raised all four arms, shouting.

“We will fight. We will *win*. So do not die!”

There was no response. But the Soldiers’ eyes burned. If they could speak, if they could only express themselves...there was no time. It was now. Pawn turned.

“Please don’t.”

He walked out of the barracks. Each of the Soldiers marched out behind him. And in minutes, in no time at all, they were fighting.

Fighting monsters.

Two hours past noon, Belgrade was screaming. He screamed at a group of Soldiers.

“Move up! Take the L4A tunnel!”

They obeyed him as he projected his thoughts at them, telling them where he needed them *now*. He should have sent five times their number, to hold off the Shield Spiders dropping out of holes in the ceiling, flooding the corridor, but Belgrade didn’t have enough reinforcements.

They were all blocked off from the fighting. A tunnel had collapsed at the wrong moment, sending two suits of magical armor falling in with them. They’d begun hacking apart the Soldiers and Workers trying to clear the rubble, and until they were destroyed, Belgrade had to hold the front on his own.

The former Worker could have laughed at the thought. A front? The network of tunnels and interlocking corridors leading from the dungeon to the Hive was anything but a unified front. Belgrade would have traded both his antennae and two of his arms for a neat, clear board like chess to fight on.

Instead, he had to defend countless tunnels at once, collapse the ones he could to stop monsters from advancing while he slaughtered as many as he could before the passages reopened. It would be easy, so easy if Belgrade could funnel his opponents into one spot, but—

The monsters *dug*. The Antinium dug, and the monsters dug. Everyone *dug*. So a monster could dig right into a corridor filled with Workers rather than fight through all the entrenched Soldiers. It meant nowhere was safe, and it meant Belgrade had to be everywhere at once.

And he was failing.

“Workers! Twenty of you—no, *forty*! Hold back the Crypt Worms in the R98 tunnel!”

A group of Workers immediately ran to an upwards-sloping tunnel, going to do battle. It was a desperation play. Anand would never have made that call. Or would he? Belgrade knew the Workers would be slaughtered in an instant, but *there were no more Soldiers*. And there were *three* Crypt Worms rampaging through the R98 tunnel at once!

The horrifically long, fleshy creatures with tendrils that could rip open carapaces and remove skin from anything they touched were difficult foes at the best of times. By now Belgrade knew they were the smaller, weaker versions of the monster Skinner, the first creature he’d ever done battle against. They lacked Skinner’s incredibly thick armor he’d built over the centuries of skin, but they could still have several layers a Soldier had to rip away, and worse, they could command the dead.

Sometimes they’d bring rotting zombies, other times skeletons or Ghouls. The worst times were when they brought undead Soldiers or Workers. It was hardest for Belgrade to fight them.

And now they were advancing. In his mind—using the [Battlefield Eye] Skill he had recently acquired, Belgrade saw the Crypt Worms advancing, tearing the Workers he’d sent to shreds.

“Hold out. We just have to hold out for more Soldiers—”

He was talking to himself as he studied the map he was constantly updating with forces. Could he take some soldiers from S41? No, they were

fighting the horrific poisonous worm things with wings. If they got through, everyone would be dying of poison. Then what about—

Belgrade's hand fell on a spot on the map, one of the corridors he and Anand had designated the 'death spots'. It was marked by a golden piece and Belgrade hadn't moved any forces to or from it.

Pawn was there. He was fighting in one of the widest corridors, places where thirty Soldiers could line up shoulder-to-shoulder. Crypt Worms often came down there, and monsters would flood the huge passageway.

"Does he have Soldiers? Can I—no!"

Belgrade jerked away. He couldn't ask Pawn for help. He didn't even know how Pawn was doing. Belgrade had let Pawn take his command to hold the tunnel, made the Antinium promise to send word if he needed reinforcements. He might be fighting with all he had. If Belgrade took his forces away...

Pawn had to survive. So long as Belgrade could keep hurling the Hive's forces at the monsters, he'd hold them off. It was a horrible thought, but the Hive had thousands of Soldiers and Workers remaining. Their concern wasn't any one particular battle, but keeping the number of Antinium the Hive produced each day higher than the average mortality rate of their people.

They just had to reopen *one* of the tunnels to let the Soldiers reinforce his position! Belgrade turned and uttered another desperate order.

"Twenty seven Workers, engage the enchanted suits of armor."

That would give them time to dig, and lose him the Workers. Belgrade turned as Workers began to move, and then heard a voice.

"No."

One of the Workers had paused. Belgrade looked at him.

"I said go—"

"No."

Workers didn't speak. It wasn't that they couldn't, it was that they never voiced their opinions. Belgrade stared as the Worker he'd ordered to fight

and die turned, and started shaking. The voice that came out of his mandibles was suddenly loud, filled with horrible madness.

“i wILl nOT. I ReFUSE. diE? DiE fOR THe HiVE? nO! pOINtleSS! i rEFuSe!”

He turned, arms shaking, and pointed at Belgrade. His hands clenched and unclenched, and then he seized the nearest Worker and grabbed the Antinium’s neck with all four hands. The Worker who’d refused *twisted* and the other Worker’s head made a *snapping* sound and he went limp.

The Workers around Belgrade froze. He froze. There was only one explanation for this Worker’s sudden behavior. He had gone insane. He’d turned against his Hive, become a killing thing that had no reason, no purpose. He had become...

An Aberration. Belgrade reached for his side. Klbkch had given him a weapon, although Belgrade had no Skills. The Worker, no, Aberration, charged at him, screaming.

“dIE!”

The Aberration ran at him, throwing off the other Workers who tried to bar his way. Belgrade waited until he was close, and then slashed with the enchanted sword he’d been given. Too slow, too late.

The former Worker ducked. Belgrade cut one of his antennae off, and then the Aberration knocked him to the ground. Two of his fists began to pummel Belgrade as the other two reached for the sword. Belgrade used all four of his arms to cling to the sword, trying to bring it to bear.

It ended when the other Workers tore the Aberration off Belgrade. He came away with one of Belgrade’s antennae. The pain was—Belgrade stumbled up and ran the Aberration through as the Workers held him down. The thing that had been a Worker kept reaching for him, trying to kill him until Belgrade twisted the blade and he went still.

Shaking, the [Tactician] got off the Aberration’s body and looked at the other Workers. They looked as shaken as he did, and they had been about to fight and die without hesitation.

“Take the body away. Now.”

Belgrade hurried back to the table. But no sooner had he used his one remaining antennae to sense what was going on than he felt a cold jolt of fear in his chest.

“Oh no. No, no!”

He looked up, and now he could hear the sounds of fighting. Belgrade turned, opening his mandibles to shout for every Worker he had to go above, but it was too late. *Something* shot down one of the tunnels, knocking aside the two Workers who’d been hauling the Aberration’s body away.

A red whip of flesh struck a Worker and pinned him to the ground. It pressed down, and the Worker was crushed into paste. Belgrade stared numbly up as the rest of the body followed, a huge, sinuous brown-red form, and a faceless head with long antennae. A worm with arms? No, something much worse.

A Crypt Worm. In his struggle, Belgrade hadn’t noticed them slaughtering the Workers. And now...they were here.

The first Crypt Worm loomed over Belgrade, slashing with its tendrils, sending the Soldiers running at it flying into walls where they broke. It was wounded in many places, but it was too large, too furious to be stopped. And it was in front of Belgrade.

And he had no more cards to play. Belgrade stared up at the Crypt Worm, suddenly calm. He’d used his Skills. The tunnel where the enchanted suits of armor were had been cleared somehow, but it was too late. His reinforcements were too far away and the Crypt Worm was looking at him.

Sword. Belgrade found it and raised it with one of his hands. He spoke, not to the Crypt Worm, but to his friend, as if he could hear him. It was just a foolish thing, but it comforted Belgrade.

“Anand. You must become strong for the both of us.”

That was it. Belgrade thought Erin might have approved. He stood up from the table as the Crypt Worm slithered towards him. A tendril shot out. Belgrade cut at it.

Again, too slow. This one sent him flying towards a wall. Belgrade heard his body *crunch* and slid to the ground. He looked—and didn't see his left arms. Either of them. He knew he should feel pain, but there was nothing.

“So—so that's what it's like. Should have sent more Soldiers.”

Belgrade wheezed as he stood. The Crypt Worm was finishing off the last Soldiers trying to fight. Now it came towards him. Belgrade looked up. How would it end? He raised his sword. Try to cut it, just once—

The Crypt Worm dove. Something flashed towards its head, and suddenly there was an empty space in the air. There was no more head. Belgrade flinched as he heard the air tearing.

The Crypt Worm fell, head torn open. It jerked, trying to stand, despite missing part of its brain, and Belgrade heard the sound again. This time he saw...

What? It looked like a white jet of something moving unbelievably fast. It tore straight through the Crypt Worm's center, cut it in half. And then... what was that?

Splattering. A spray. Some of it had blasted backwards from impact and struck Belgrade. He flinched, and then studied the liquid on him. It wasn't blood. It was...

“Water?”

He got up. Belgrade was bleeding, but he had to see. He turned down the corridor the water had come from, as two more Crypt Worms shot down the passageway, and a group of Shield Spiders burst out of one of the tunnels. Everywhere was being overrun. Too late. Had to retreat. But all of Belgrade's hazy thoughts stopped when he saw her, shining like the sun.

Xrn.

She was holding a staff in the air, a staff with a crystal orb. Her eyes shone with every color Belgrade had ever known and more he hadn't. And from her came light. A piercing, brilliant light that made the Crypt Worms flinch away, screaming in high-pitched voices. But the light was soothing to Belgrade and all the Antinium who saw it.

Then she spoke. And her voice was thunder.

“I am Xrn, the Small Queen!”

It echoed down the cavern, filling the minds of the struggling Workers and Soldiers. They turned and saw her holding her staff high, the light emanating from it shining like a sun underground. Xrn raised one hand, and called a word.

“[Burning Lightning].”

Something red and orange and brilliant shot past Belgrade. He turned, and saw one of the Crypt Worms *shriek* as lightning struck and turned the creature’s skin and body into flame. It writhed, and died. Just like that.

With one spell. Xrn strode forwards, and Belgrade saw Soldiers and Workers running after her, ahead of her. It looked like the entire Hive. They flooded the tunnels, abandoning their duties, called by her voice. Xrn pointed at the monsters rushing towards Belgrade’s position and shouted.

“Stand, Antinium. Fight, Antinium! In the name of your Hive, stand with me and push back the invaders!”

Some of the Workers had survived the Crypt Worm’s attack. They rose. Belgrade was already running. He didn’t think, he just ran. The first of the Shield Spiders was crawling towards Belgrade. It reared up, half-blind from the light and Belgrade cut it apart with his sword. He was shouting. A worker charged into a Shield Spider, threw it down. And then the tunnel was full of Antinium, fighting, pushing back the stunned Shield Spiders with a ferocity unknown even to Soldiers.

They charged into the tide of monsters, a black wave of flesh and carapace that smashed the first rank of monsters to pieces. The Crypt Worms lashed out, but the Workers clung to them and the Soldiers tore flesh from the writhing, screaming horrors.

Xrn swept a wave of blasting steam down one corridor, broiling a group of obscenely large maggot-butterflies that were shedding a poisonous miasma. She was not alone. The Silent Antinium raced past her, half-invisible, disappearing from Belgrade’s sight. The sword-wielding clones of Klbkch formed a shield around Xrn as she cast spells. She planted her staff in the ground, and burnt a Crypt Worm to ash as the Custodium dueled a suit of enchanted armor, nimbly dodging and cutting at it, their enchanted blades slashing through the thick steel.

The Silent Antinium, the thin assassins with scythes for arms, brought down a group of the huge not-Gnolls, as Belgrade marshaled the Soldiers and Workers around him, sending them to reinforce Xrn's position.

The transparent Antinium leapt from a wall where they had been waiting, practically invisible and beheaded two of the lumbering monsters before they realized what was happening. Their scythes were as sharp as any blade and in moments they were moving away from the bloody remains of the group.

"For the Armored Antinium! Flying Antinium, cover our backs!"

Someone strode down the corridor, shouting. Belgrade saw Tersk, for some reason *unarmored* and not holding his mace and shield, leading his Soldiers and a few of the Flying Antinium at a group of ghouls and zombies. Belgrade went to run after him, and fell.

It was the blood loss. Belgrade stared up at the dirt ceiling as Antinium raced around him. He expected to die, but again he was surprised.

"Belgrade. Hold still."

Someone reached down for him. Belgrade felt a soft hand on his chest, and then the bleeding stopped. He felt something *warm* rush into him, something that felt like hope given form. He sat up, filled with...some kind of energy.

Xrn was looking down at him. She shone with magic. And when she pulled him up, Belgrade realized all his injuries had closed. He looked at Xrn, and she told him to follow. She led the way, forcing monsters back. And Belgrade stared at her.

Xrn. The Small Queen. [Thaumaturge]. Not [Mage]. Not [Wizard], or [Sorceress], or [Witch]. She didn't practice just magic. What Xrn worked was something else.

Wonders.

They pushed the monsters back. Xrn raised waves of poisonous waters, flooded the tunnels, made the wind into swords and threw it at her enemies. Belgrade accompanied her, protected by a ring of silent Custodium, the equivalent of any Prognugators.

They found Pawn in the death corridor, still fighting. His Soldiers struggled with a group of the not-Gnolls until Xrn raised her staff.

“[Fear of the Mighty]!”

They fled. Belgrade rushed over to Pawn. The Worker was at the back of the group of Soldiers, sheltered by them. Belgrade halted when he saw the painted Soldiers. Their markings were barely visible under the coating of blood and flesh that covered them. Not a single Soldier was unharmed, but Pawn—

There wasn't a mark on him.

Pawn turned to Belgrade. The gore had barely touched him, protected as he was by his Soldiers. He was holding something, someone in his arms.

A Soldier. Belgrade stared down at the huge Antinium. He could be held in Pawn's arms, because there wasn't any part of the Soldier below his chest. And yet, he was alive. Pawn held the Soldier as the huge Antinium struggled to clasp his hands. The Soldier's mandibles clicked together, as if he wanted to speak.

But he never did. He died there, as Xrn cleared the passageway. Belgrade knelt beside Pawn. The other Antinium looked at him.

“We were fighting, but there were so many. We lost countless Soldiers and Workers. You were right Belgrade, they were everywhere. My Soldiers fought, but...”

“How many?”

Belgrade could see many of the painted Soldiers. So many, in fact! Compared to the dead monsters, there were so many Soldiers. For this many dead, Pawn should have been overrun long ago. But Pawn closed his mandibles, covered his eyes with one bloody hand.

“Twenty five.”

“Only twenty five?”

Belgrade stared at Pawn. The Worker nodded.

“I couldn't do anything. My one [Tactician] Skill—they died, Belgrade! They died!”

“It was only twenty five. Pawn, your battle here was a tactical victory. It
—”

Someone pulled him back. Belgrade turned and saw Xrn. She shook her head slowly. Pawn had covered both his eyes with his hands, but the other two desperately held the Soldier still. He shook. But he did not cry.

The Antinium could not cry.

Belgrade stepped away. Xrn was the one who knelt next to Pawn. There was the deepest blue in her eyes, a color more vast than the sea, darker than night. She touched the Soldier in Pawn’s arm and looked at him.

“I am sorry.”

Pawn did not reply.

They did not bury the Soldier. That was not how the Antinium treated the dead. Instead, the Soldier was taken to be processed. He would be food soon enough.

Pawn knew it. He knew it, and he knew it wasn’t *right*. But the Soldier was dead. And there weren’t—weren’t enough pieces of the others.

He sat in the barracks, still bloody, as the Soldiers still able to move clustered around him. The Soldiers who hadn’t fought stood with their brethren, clumsily tending to their wounds. They were all wounded. And not enough of them.

Twenty five dead. Exactly a quarter of his command, of his people. Pawn had expected—he had known—

He hadn’t been ready. No.

He could still see the Soldier who’d died. He had a small five-pointed star on his upper right arm. That was all. He’d only taken that lone marking. And he’d died, protecting Pawn from a—a tendril that had reached out and *cut* him in two.

He was dead. It was Pawn's fault. And there was nothing left of him to remember. Nothing. Just a memory. For all Pawn had done—

Pawn stood up. No. The Soldier couldn't be forgotten. He stumbled past the Soldiers as they parted for him. He ran over to one wall of the barracks, to the spot that had been cleared. Pawn knelt by the cans of paint he'd bought, pawing through them frantically. Which color was it? This one? No. This one.

The Worker stood with a jar of paint in his hand. The other Soldiers stared. It was bright green paint, the same color the dead Soldier had used. Pawn slowly dipped his finger into the jar, and turned.

The walls of the barracks the Soldiers lived in were dirt. Not loose dirt, but hard-packed, as good as stone and unbreakable in most circumstances. Pawn found a spot along the wall. It didn't stand out from any other spot. He dipped a finger into the bright green paint.

And then he pressed it against the wall.

Pawn slowly drew on the wall of the barracks. The other Soldiers watched as Pawn traced on the hard-packed dirt with green paint. He drew a star. The star that had been on the Soldier's chest.

It was small. It was green. It was a tiny thing in the vast barracks. But it was there. Painted on the wall, marked. A memory. So long as no one damaged the paint, no one destroyed the wall, it would remain.

And if they did? If an earthquake happened, or Klbkch told him to get rid of it? Pawn would repaint the star elsewhere. Because he remembered. He remembered that star, and he would for the rest of his life.

And so did the others. Pawn turned as a Soldier moved. The Soldier found a jar of purple paint. Slowly, carefully, taking all the time in the world, he drew purple slashes down the wall.

Another Soldier moved. He took some paint and began to draw. The other Soldiers, wounded and intact, did the same. They did not have to speak. They did not have to confer. Twenty five Soldiers had died, but each living Soldier remembered.

So did Pawn.

When they were done, the barracks were not covered in paint. There were only a few, small places where the walls had been colored in. The symbols were small. But they were there.

A green star, a...cup of brown and silver. A clumsy number '7' in turquoise. A speckled egg, white and blue and orange. A sun rising over a green horizon. A green flower. A rainstorm and clouds all in blue. A snowflake in purest white. A black cat with orange eyes. A circle of red, mixed with yellow.

Five numbers, 46252, each in a different color. A picture of a bee on a plate, clumsily drawn. A smiley face. A stick-person with four arms. A word. 'Winter'.

A map of the Hive. Eight lines and a curvy wave beneath it all. Two stones, one shaped like a face, the other like no stone ever seen. A question mark, drawn out of brown and a pale blue so bright it could have been white.

A line that looped and spun and dove. A cloud made of pink and yellow. A paw print in white. The memory of the first Soldier ever to be painted.

A cup running over with water. A sun and four moons.

A blade of grass.

Pawn stared at it all. Each Soldier was there, on the wall. Their bodies were gone, but there they were. He ran his hands along the dried paint, and felt something there.

Small things. Shapes and symbols, things that held meaning only the Soldier that had chosen them would know. Fragments of their soul.

It was not enough. It could never be enough. But it was something. It was something to cling to. Pawn looked at the Soldiers, covered in paint, in blood. He knelt as they clustered around him, putting awkward hands on him. Pawn could not look at them. He whispered the words.

"I am so sorry."

They said nothing. But they held him, clumsy killers, people with no voices who wore their souls on their chests for all to see. Pawn looked at them and wept. His eyes shed not a tear. They were his. His Soldiers. His guardians. His friends.

His people.

He embraced them. Pawn wept again, without tears. Then he went to see Erin.

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4.14 L

Once upon a time there was a [Princess]. She was bad at being a princess. She never leveled, and she ran away from home, no doubt causing a lot of trouble because of that. She ran in a childish fit of anger, and ended up on another continent, where she caused more trouble because she was petty and small-minded and useless. Then she died.

The end.

That was how the story should have gone. Every day Lyonette du Marquin knew she should have died a long time ago, cold, alone, lying in the snow. She knew that, and so she tried to be grateful for the second—no, probably eighth—chance she'd been given.

It wasn't hard to be grateful. Because Lyonette had everything she'd wanted. In some senses, she'd found exactly what she'd come to Izril to find.

She had a job, something to do that mattered. She had a duty, to protect Mrsha, to take care of the inn. And what was more, she had what she'd wanted for so long.

Levels. Classes. Skills. For the first time since she was seven years old, Lyon was actually leveling again. Not just gaining a level every few *years*. She was gaining levels rapidly. Not as a [Princess], true, but as a far humbler class. A [Barmaid]. Perhaps it was below her station, but Lyonette didn't care. Because she had *Skills!*

[Charming Smile]. [Lesser Strength]. These were her two latest Skills, obtained as she'd reached Level 11 in the [Barmaid] class. They made her happy and slightly ashamed. Happy because they were Skills, and ashamed because the part of Lyonette that still thought of herself as royalty knew these Skills weren't what she should be hoping for.

A [Princess] should not have a Skill that let her lift heavy objects, Lyonette knew. True, a Skill like [Charming Smile] *was* a very Princess-like Skill, although a [Princess] should not smile so openly for no reason. But these weren't grand Skills, the kind that could aid her nation or inspire her people. They were just...Skills.

And yet, her entire life, all eighteen years she'd lived, Lyonette had only had one small Skill from her [Princess] class. Just one Skill while everyone else learned more Skills and leveled. This was better, truly.

Lyonette was grateful for it. She was a Level 11 [Barmaid], a Level 4 [Beast Tamer], a Level 6 [Carer], a Level 2 [Tactician], and...a Level 5 [Princess]. She knew she had far too many classes, that she should only have one.

She didn't care. Lyonette was more grateful to Erin Solstice, the [Innkeeper] and owner of the Wandering Inn, than she could say. Erin was almost always cheerful, always helpful, brave, and kind. If she had one flaw, it was that she was also impulsive.

And that sometimes made trouble for Lyonette. Sudden party? Lyonette would be rushing around to fill orders by herself and washing dishes all next morning. Erin's selling magical food to adventurers? Time to buy another five kegs of alcohol! Where did all the food go? Erin cooked it all? Back to the city.

Lyonette usually didn't begrudge these decisions. However, this time she wished, just a tiny bit, that Erin had consulted her.

The younger girl stared at Erin's beaming face and then her eyes slid sideways. It was just past dawn, and it was a bit too early for thinking. Cleaning and hauling water, that was okay. But this?

"You hired...all of them?"

"Yup! This is Safry and Maran, Selys' friend Drassi, and a Gnoll that Krshia introduced me to—he's Ishkr. They're all going to be helping you out! Isn't it great?"

Lyonette stared as the two young women Erin had pointed out, the yellow-scaled Drake, and a Gnoll with red-brown fur waved or nodded to her. She blinked a few more times and then turned her head.

Ryoka Griffin, the strange Runner with exotic features was eying the new staff with as much skepticism as Lyon felt. Mrsha was sitting on top of Ryoka's shoulders, detracting from the girl's poise as she chewed on a cracker and showered Ryoka with crumbs. Lyonette looked back at Erin and smiled weakly.

“Yes. Great, Erin!”

Erin never talked to her about her plans. One day she announced she’d be hiring the Antinium to add a *third floor* to the inn and that the Antinium named Bird would be living here from now on as a guard, the next...*this*.

In fairness, Lyonette had really respected hiring Bird. She’d never felt safe without someone who could fight. But these new people...Lyonette didn’t know anything about them. Erin clearly thought they were competent, but it was also clear after a few moments that there would be trouble.

“Alright, I’ll start cooking breakfast, lunch and dinner. You all can uh, well, clean up. And I need some water. Lyonette, can you show everyone how things work? Thanks!”

And like that, Lyonette found herself dealing with another one of Erin’s new ideas. The [Princess] turned [Barmaid] took a deep breath and then smiled at the people Erin had hired. They were all staring at each other with a bit of wariness, but maybe this wouldn’t be so bad!

“Hello everyone. I’m Lyonette. I’m a Level 11 [Barmaid], and I’m very happy to be working with you.”

“Pleased.”

The woman called Safry smiled at Lyonette. She would have said something else, but Drassi spoke up. And kept speaking.

“Are you the [Thief] that got kicked out of the city? I was going to watch, but I was working and Selys said it wasn’t that exciting. And that’s the scary Gnoll kid right? Hi! I’m Drassi, a Level 8 [Barmaid]. Well, I was also working as a [Receptionist], but I like waiting tables more since you have to sit in one place as a [Receptionist].”

Lyonette blinked as a wall of words hit her ears. It was rather like listening to Octavia deliver one of her sales pitches, only Drassi was just talking. Chattering, rather.

The Drake cut off as the Gnoll, Ishkr, cleared his throat. He looked around.

“Hrr. I am a Level 16 [Waiter], yes? Honored Krshia recommended that I work here.”

That was it. Drassi opened her mouth, but it was Maran, the other Human woman who spoke up.

“Really? In that case, Safry and I are the highest-leveled workers here.”

Everyone stared at them. Ryoka and Mrsha had already gone off to play ‘don’t crawl on my head’. Safry smiled as Maran pointed at her friend.

“Safry’s a Level 21 [Barmaid] and I’m a Level 22 [Barmaid]. We’ll look after things and teach you all how things work. Lyonette, Erin said we’re cleaning, right? Where are the supplies? And what’s this about water?”

Lyonette stared at Maran. Wait, what had she said? *They’d* teach her? But—

That should have been the first clue. But then Lyonette heard Zel coming down the stairs, so she just grabbed a few of the dust rags, a bucket of soapy water and showed the others which tables were clean before hurrying out the door. Yes, looking back on it that was the start.

The start of a few truly miserable days for Lyonette du Marquin.

Two Human [Barmaids], a Drake [Server], and a Gnoll. It sounded like a recipe for disaster.

And it was. Upon getting back, puffing and panting with more water, the first thing Lyonette saw was chaos. Maran and Safry were serving food to the bemused Gold-rank adventurers who’d come down, Zel was waiting patiently for his food while Drassi cleaned and talked his earholes off, and Ishkr was waiting for instructions, standing at attention by the kitchen. Mrsha was sniffing at him as he tried to shoo her away. And Erin was shouting that she needed more pots to hold all the food she was going to make ahead of time! Lyonette nearly screamed.

After half a day of work, Lyonette realized that things weren’t as bad as she’d thought, and they were worse than she could have imagined.

The inn was busy from dawn till dusk now, mainly due to Erin advertising her magical cooking to the adventurers in Liscor. You could stop by for a quick bite before going out hunting monsters or braving the dungeon, and you'd have an enchantment that would last for hours, at a fraction of the cost of a normal potion!

This amazing opportunity meant that Erin's inn always had a steady flow of visitors, mainly adventurers looking for one type of magical food or another. Everyone was busy, and Erin had set up the schedules so that not all of the staff would work at the same time. Sometimes, like around dinner, all four of the new workers might be helping at once, but usually Lyonette would be working with two or three of the others at most.

That gave her time to relax and play with Mrsha, in theory. But Erin hadn't accounted for the need to teach the new workers everything, and since she was busy 'hanging out' with Ryoka, an expression that meant going shopping, chatting, and generally enjoying herself in Celum and Liscor, the duties once again fell to Lyonette.

It gave her the opportunity to learn about the others. And what Lyonette learned was that she didn't actually mind some of them. They had their negative qualities, true, but also good ones.

Drassi, for instance. She talked. No, she gossiped, no, she *conversed* with anyone and everyone nearby. She could chat about Drake politics and switch over to a serious discussion about the latest Human fashions in a second. But while that could be annoying, she was always chattering away while she cleaned a table, or served food. She didn't linger.

That couldn't be said for Maran and Safry. They worked, talked, and when they were done serving, they sat around and talked with the inn's guests. At first Lyonette thought they were just taking a short break, but it became apparent that when there was no more food or drink to be served, the two [Barmaids] would just sit down and relax, rather than clean tables, wash dishes, or get more water or firewood from outside.

"We can do that later. After the inn closes. Relax!"

"The inn doesn't close until Erin sleeps, and that's after midnight!"

Lyon argued with Maran as the other woman sat with a drink. Maran looked slightly off put, and then shrugged.

“We’ll do it when more dishes pile up. There’s barely more than a few cups and plates.”

“But—”

Lyonette tried to think of how to insist without forcing the issue, but Ishkr beat her to a reply.

“I will do it, yes? I have time.”

He headed into the kitchen, rolling the sleeves of the uniform he was wearing up. Maran gave Lyon a smile as if to say, ‘you see, there’s no problem.’ By her side, Safry watched Ishkr go in and leaned towards the other two Humans and whispered conspiratorially.

“I hope he doesn’t get fur all over the dishes. How does a Gnoll wash plates anyways? With his tongue?”

Maran giggled, but Lyon gave Safry a look that wiped the smile off the other woman’s face.

“With his paws, I imagine.”

That was the issue. Not Ishkr. The Gnoll had been hesitant at first, but when he was told what to do, he did it without complaints. He wasn’t talkative, but he seemed to enjoy idle work, the kind he could get engrossed in without talking to anyone for good periods of time. Better yet, he didn’t have a problem with Mrsha’s white fur.

“I was born and raised in Liscor, yes? I do not know many of my tribe’s superstitions. Honored Krshia says the child is alright, so I will not mind.”

That put him in Lyon’s good books. No, Ishkr and Drassi weren’t the problems. The problem pair were Maran and Safry, by a long shot.

It wasn’t that they didn’t work as hard. Well, it was partly that. But Lyonette just didn’t like them as much. For a while, the girl had wondered if she felt threatened, but she realized it was because of how Maran and Safry seemed to regard Lyonette’s advice as suggestions and thought of themselves as in charge.

Even when they didn’t have a clue of what to do. In the mid-lunch rush as adventurers came to eat magical food, normal food, or just drink, Lyonette saw Safry delivering one of Erin’s Corusdeer scrambles to a

waiting Drake. She called out, but Safry didn't pay attention until she was on her way back to the kitchen.

"What's the problem Lyonette? I served him his food."

"No, no! That's the wrong Drake! He's eating the wrong food!"

Lyonette hurried over to the Drake. When she came back, after apologizing profusely, Safry made a face.

"How can *you* tell the difference? That looks like the same Drake to me!"

"He's not! Look at his scales!"

"They're green. All of those Drakes have green scales too!"

"No!"

How could they not tell? Lyonette looked at the green-scaled Drakes that Safry had pointed out as proof, and saw an elderly Drake male with patches of grey scales, a Drake warrior with a speckled pattern across his far lighter green scales, and a Drake with darker green scales and some distinctively long spines along the back of his head. When she pointed this all out to Safry, the woman just looked confused.

"Where are you seeing all that? They still look sort of the same. Okay, the old guy I can see, but Drakes aren't distinctive like us Humans."

Lyonette bit her lip. She'd heard Drakes and Gnolls say the exact same thing. And to be fair, most of the people on this continent had light skin, whereas Drakes and Gnolls had all kinds of variation among their fur.

"How about this. Next time, why don't you ask if this is his order? If you know his name, you can check to make sure. It'll just take a second and I'm sure they wouldn't mind—"

Safry's eyebrows crossed, and she raised a hand to cut Lyonette off.

"Look Lyon, I appreciate the advice, but Maran and I know what to do. You just point out the right Drakes and Gnolls and we'll do our job."

Lyonette stared at Safry, but the woman turned away too quickly for her to respond.

That was the first big issue Lyon had. The second came when she noticed they were running low on water. They were *always* running low on water to cook with, boil for drinking, wash with, use for cleaning, and so on.

“Maran, can you go get some more water?”

Lyon was busy serving a group of Gnolls that the two Human [Barmaids] couldn’t tell apart. Maran stared at Lyon, then her eyes flicked to the Gnoll [Server].

“Why not Ishkr? He’s free, and he’s stronger than me.”

Lyonette paused feeling angry. It was true Ishkr was free for the moment, he had just worked his entire shift and Safry and Maran had just had lunch! Moreover, why was Maran’s first response to ask someone else to do the work?

“Ishkr needs to have his lunch break. You just finished yours.”

“But we still have some water left.”

“Some, but we’ll be out soon!”

The Gnolls sitting at the table eyed Lyonette as she went over to argue with Maran. They flicked their eyes at Ishkr, who made some motion behind Lyon’s back she couldn’t see. Maran clearly didn’t want to go.

“It’s cold out there. This isn’t a [Barmaid]’s job, you know.”

“Erin told you you’d be working here, right? This is what we do.”

“I want to talk to Erin about this. This isn’t what I was hired for.”

Lyonette’s patience was at an end. She felt like she was dealing with a child, not an adult.

“You can do it when she comes back. Just go now, please. And take two buckets!”

She thrust another one into the affronted woman’s hand and practically pushed her out the door. Lyonette got back to serving, apologizing to the Gnolls. She waited for Maran to come back. And waited. And waited...

Maran returned after twenty minutes, twice as long as it should have taken, just when Lyonette was about to go look for her. She was irate at

having to carry the buckets up the hill in the snow. And they weren't fully filled!

Lyonette bit back her words when she saw Maran's face and instead thanked her. Twelve minutes later, she wished she could have taken back the thanks when Safry began to complain about Mrsha.

"Hey, can you do something about her?"

She was pointing at Mrsha as the Gnoll tried to sneak up on the group of Gnolls. They were letting her do it, and one would turn to stare at her when Mrsha got ready to pounce on a tail. Thereafter Mrsha would run about excitedly. Lyonette saw nothing but pure fun in Mrsha's game, but Safry was clearly displeased at having to watch to avoid Mrsha being underfoot.

"The kid's cute, but we're trying to work. Can't you make her go upstairs or play outside?"

"Just ask her to move. It's no problem."

"She's in the way every two seconds. Why not let her run outside if she's so excited?"

Lyonette stared at Safry.

"There are monsters outside. She's not causing that much trouble and she needs the room."

Maran spoke up as she swabbed a table. She made a face as she held up a rag full of white hairs.

"She's getting fur all over the tables and chairs we already cleaned."

"So? Just clean them again? It's only a few wipes of the rag."

The two [Barmaids] looked at each other, clearly displeased. Lyonette had to turn away so they wouldn't see the look on her face.

Small things. Small things that would go away. That was what she told herself, but then Bird came by and things got...awkward.

He wanted a drink, and he had some birds for Erin. Simple, right? Only Maran and Safry left him sitting until *Drassi* got a drink, and although Maran had a pitcher of refills, she kept seeming to miss Bird.

"Just fill his cup! What's the problem?"

“He’s—don’t you think it’s weird? He’s one of them! One of the Antinium!”

It was only then that Lyon realized how clearly uncomfortable Maran and Safry were around Bird. They walked wide of the Antinium, not going near him if they could serve other customers. Drassi and Ishkr were far more relaxed around the Antinium, having seen them before, but Safry and Maran weren’t happy with him around.

“That Antinium in the Horns of Hammerad was one thing, but is he going to be here *all* the time? He just stares and talks about birds!”

Lyonette crossed her arms as Maran complained.

“Erin’s going to hire him permanently. He’ll stay here all the time as a guard.”

The woman looked dismayed. Safry shook her head.

“Maybe he’ll stay upstairs where we don’t see him. I’d hate to turn around and just see him there. Staring.”

Not once had Lyonette ever felt uncomfortable from Bird’s stare. He was just curious, and she never felt uneasy around him. She opened her mouth, and turned away.

When Erin came back, a few hours before dinner, Lyon had never been more relieved. She would have loved to chat with Erin, but dinner had to be made ready, and Erin was far too busy laughing with Maran and Safry for Lyon to pull her aside to talk about...Maran and Safry.

Indeed, while Erin was around, things suddenly began to work smooth as butter. Neither Maran nor Safry had a problem with the Gold-rank teams, the Horns of Hammerad and Zel in the crowd, mainly because everyone was distinctively, and largely, Human. Lyon rushed about until Erin pulled her aside. She was sitting with Ryoka, eating rather than cooking or serving for once and looking pleased as a cat about it.

“Isn’t this cool, Lyonette? I can take a break!”

“Um. Yes.”

Lyonette bit back the words she wanted to say. Erin smiled up at her.

“So how was everyone? Did Drassi talk a lot? Selys says she does that, but she swears Drassi’s a hard worker. Oh, and did Ishkr do okay with Mrsha? I was worried about that but he seems cool!”

“They both did great, Erin.”

“Awesome! So there were no problems?”

Safry and Maran were walking around, serving the tables and talking with the adventurers. Too near. And it was only day one, right? Lyonette felt she couldn’t say anything. So in the end she didn’t. She only mentioned Maran’s reluctance to get water.

Erin groaned aloud when Lyon brought that up, but she was already nodding cheerfully when Lyon was finished explaining.

“Oh, the water? I guess I didn’t mention that to them. I’ll talk with Safry and Maran about it, okay?”

And that was that. Erin had a word and then came back to assure Lyon that water wouldn’t be a problem. Lyon tried to take Erin at her word, but she really couldn’t. She just felt like something was wrong.

Then in the middle of the night, Lyonette woke up and realized what was wrong. Safry and Maran thought they were in charge. Because they were higher level. But Lyon was. Right? She’d been working here longer, so she should know what to do. Right?

But it occurred to her as Mrsha rolled over and Ryoka snored loudly from her corner of the room that Erin had never mentioned who was in charge while she was gone. Maybe Erin hadn’t thought about it. But it mattered. It mattered...quite a lot.

The second day was no better than the first. It started out promising, with Safry and Maran turning up exactly when they were supposed to and cleaning last night’s dishes and the room cheerfully while talking with Erin.

The trouble started the moment Erin left to hang out with Ryoka in Celum. Lyonette missed her chance to ask Erin who’d be in charge while

she left. She felt awkward just bringing it up—it felt as though Lyon was *trying* to get Erin to give her more authority, when it was really an important matter.

Either way, it meant there was no leader, and so the duo of Safry and Maran butted heads with Lyon over countless issues as the day wore on. It began with tips, and came to a head with buckets of water.

This time Erin had left the inn before breakfast had ended. She'd already cooked up days of food in advance, a handy suggestion of Ryoka's that was convenient all around. But it meant that the Gold-rank adventurers and the Horns of Hammerad were eating at the same time as Zel. And wouldn't you know it, but Safry and Maran seemed to serve food first to the Gold-rank adventurers and leave Zel for last.

"Hey, you're not serving Zel first. Bring the sausages to his table—he's been waiting the longest!"

Lyonette caught Safry's arm as she went out holding a steaming plate of reheated sausage. The [Barmaid] frowned at Lyon.

"Why? He'll get some in a minute. But the *Gold*-rank adventurers are sitting over there, Lyonette!"

"So?"

Safry rolled her eyes.

"So, they might tip us!"

Lyonette paused. She looked accusingly at Safry.

"I thought you told Erin you didn't get any tips!"

"Well, obviously not from normal folk. But Gold-rank adventurers throw their money around like water, especially for good service! If you smile the right way at some of the men, they'll give you a gold coin just for serving their table!"

She moved away from Lyonette and to her outrage, served Griffon Hunt first. And indeed, both Safry and Maran flirted with Halrac, Ulrien, and Typhenous, who might have been twice as old as they were! Lyonette nearly swallowed her tongue when she saw that, but according to Safry and Maran, that too was customary.

“You don’t understand how being a [Barmaid] works, Lyonette. You need to pay attention to the most important customer.”

Safry’s arch tone made Lyon want to kick her. She pointed towards Zel, who was eating sausage with Mrsha, oblivious to the drama.

“Oh yeah? Well *he’s* a Drake [General]. Why don’t you shake your hips for him?”

Both Safry and Maran’s jaws dropped. They exchanged a speculative glance, and then Maran shook her head.

“Eh, I don’t want to flirt with him. What if he took it seriously?”

Safry nodded. Lyon ground her teeth together. It wasn’t the idea of Zel and Maran together that was upsetting her—that was pretty much impossible—it was how Maran had phrased her words.

“What’s wrong with him? What if one of Griffon Hunt took things seriously?”

“Well, that’s different. Obviously.”

Maran looked surprised Lyon had to ask.

“Ulrien and Halrac are fine, and so is the old [Mage], I guess.”

Safry made a face, but nodded reluctantly. Maran cast her eyes over to the other adventurers in the room and shook her head.

“But the half-Giant’s obviously no good, and neither is the fish man. Ugh. No way. And the others are all female...at least there’s that handsome [Mage] sitting with the Horns of Hammerad.”

She pointed to Pisces appreciatively. Lyon stared at Maran, and her dislike of her and Safry grew four times larger in that moment. She smiled bitterly at both of them.

“Who? Pisces? Go ahead if you want. He’s a [Necromancer], you know.”

She left the two horrified women and stomped away.

Midway through the day, Lyonette paused to check how much water they had left. There was a good amount, but a fit of pique made her go and ask Maran to get more water. She expected the other woman to resist, but she wasn't expecting an outright refusal. But that was what she got.

"There is no way I'm going out there. Neither is Safry."

"Why not?"

Maran's face was set.

"There are fish with *teeth* in the water. That's what Erin said! And Rock Crabs? Shield Spiders? I'm not doing it."

Lyonette stared at her, and realized Maran hadn't been told of Liscor's natural hazards before now. Drassi and Ishkr accepted the slight danger as a matter of course, but Maran's face was white at just the thought of running into one of the monsters.

"Look, Maran, it will be fine. Just take a seed core and—"

"No!"

It was customary now for Lyonette to use some of the wizened, dried-up seed cores that Erin had stored from the blue fruits just in case a Rock Crab showed up. She'd scared one away twice by now, and knew they weren't a threat if you had your eyes halfway open. But Maran was insistent.

"I'll get some water from Celum instead."

"What, from a well there? Fine. But if you're going—"

"No! I'll do it like civilized folk do and have it delivered! You can pay to have water barrels sent to your inn or home each day. It's just a few silver coins—a few more for a fast delivery, but it's safe."

Silver coins for *water*? Lyonette gaped at Maran and then shook her head.

"You can't do that. Just go and get some water!"

"I won't. If you need them, get it yourself or get the other two to do it. But Safry and I won't get water from now on. You can melt snow in the buckets if you want."

That was it. Lyonette crossed her arms, too frustrated to let this go. She glared at Maran, who was staring hard at Lyon, mouth a firm line.

“We need water, and Erin told you this was part of her job. No one else is getting water, so until you go—”

“I’ll just pay for some water to be delivered here! Erin’s got enough money.”

Maran went over to the bar’s counter and to Lyonette’s horror, opened the lid of the money jar where Erin collected the day’s earnings. She went to stop Maran, but Safry got in her way.

“Erin’s *not* going to pay for barrels of water when she can just get it from the stream.”

“Well that’s too bad, because I’m not going to get some and risk my life.”

Maran marched over to the door leading to Celum. Before Lyon could stop her, she’d disappeared through with a handful of coins from Erin’s money jar. She came back thirty minutes later, and Lyonette watched six huge barrels of water come through the doorway with butterflies of panic and anger fluttering about in her stomach. She took a deep, shuddering breath, and walked right past Maran’s smug face.

Lyonette was furious Maran had wasted Erin’s money. But deep down she was also pleased. It meant that there would be trouble, and that both [Barmaids] would get what was coming to them. At least, Lyonette hoped that was the case.

“Hey Lyon. Get Mrsha off the table!”

Safry was trying to clear the plates off of one and Mrsha was happily trying to steal scraps. She flicked her hands at Mrsha, trying to shoo her off, but Mrsha just saw that as an invitation to play. Lyonette hurried over and pulled Mrsha away. Safry glared, and Lyonette glared back.

The other woman broke the stare-off by glancing towards the door.

“By the way, one of the Antinium things was here earlier. Not the Bird one...this one called himself Pawn or something.”

“What? Pawn?”

Lyonette dropped Mrsha in her excitement. Pawn was alive! Erin had been so worried.

“Where is he?”

Safry shrugged.

“I don’t know. He was looking for Erin, so I told him to come back later because Erin’s not here. We’re busy cleaning up breakfast, so—”

“No!”

Lyonette clutched at her hair. She screamed at Safry, right in the woman’s surprised face. How could she turn away *Pawn*, just because she was afraid of the Antinium? He was a guest, and she—

“We *always* let the Antinium in! Always! Is he still nearby? How far did he go?”

She rushed out the door before the woman could respond.

Death. Pawn had known it would come to that. He’d known it, but not really *known*. There had been some stupid, foolish part of him that had imagined fighting with his Soldiers, triumphing over the monsters and not losing a single one.

What a fool he had been. The Antinium dragged himself away from Erin’s inn. She wasn’t there. And he was empty.

His Soldiers had died. Twenty five of them. But far more had died that weren’t his. He’d heard Belgrade give the report to Klbkch. Over two hundred Workers and about half the number of Soldiers had perished while they’d been fighting. Two hundred.

These weren’t devastating numbers. The Hive had suffered worse, and always come back. New Workers and Soldiers were always being created. That also meant each day they were also dying. If not by the hundreds, at least a dozen.

Each day. Each day, a dozen Soldiers like the ones who lived on the walls of the barracks in paint died. Each day. Pawn could barely fathom that. No—it was because he couldn't imagine such a thing that he was still able to function at all.

Workers died. Soldiers died. They died and their bodies were turned to mush that other Antinium ate. Each day. If you dwelt on that, you'd curl up and die, like the Workers who never woke up and were carried away. Or worse—you'd become an Aberration.

That was how they were created, surely. Pawn had come close, once. He felt that had to be why. It was when you couldn't make sense of it all, when the death and emptiness crushed you down and left not even loyalty, not even the shred of...of anything. That was when it happened.

He wanted to talk to Erin about it. But she wasn't there. The strange Human who hadn't met his eyes had said so.

So Pawn would go back. He'd go back and—

"Pawn!"

Someone called his name. Pawn looked up. He saw a figure running down the hill, waving her arms and shouting at him. Not Erin. But someone nearly as good.

Lyonette. She seized him, hugged him. Pawn stood still in the snow, wordless, as Lyonette sobbed in relief that she'd gotten to him before he'd gone back to his Hive.

"I thought you might be dead! Come on, come back to the inn. I'll get you food, and your favorite bee, and you can wait for Erin—"

"But the Human female said Erin—"

"You can wait for her! Don't listen to Safry! Come on!"

In no time, Pawn was sitting in the inn, Mrsha sniffing at his hands, a mug of hot honey milk in his hand, and a plate with a dead bee practically dripping with butter and honey wafting enticingly up at him. The bee was making two of the Human [Barmaids] scream and argue with Lyonette. Pawn listened and thought Lyonette sounded angry, until the door from Celum burst open and Erin and Ryoka rushed through.

“Pawn!”

Erin’s voice was like the sun. He rose as she ran at him. She threw her arms around Pawn and hugged him tightly. It was like finding his name again. Pawn hugged her back, carefully, and saw another girl he recognized standing behind her. Ryoka Griffin.

When Erin let go, fussing over Pawn, Ryoka approached.

“Pawn, right? I’m Ryoka. We’ve met before, but I haven’t talked with you.”

She held out a hand. Pawn stared at it, and gingerly shook it. Ryoka Griffin was nothing like Erin, but she was reassuring in her own way. She had spoken to Klbkch, Pawn knew, and Erin had always spoken highly of her. She was intriguing to him.

But now Erin was fussing about him, and telling him to tell her *everything*. Pawn looked at her, and felt the same pain, the helplessness, hurt bubbling up inside him.

“What happened Pawn? Was it bad? Why did Klbkch tell you to fight?”

“It was...”

He couldn’t talk about the Hive. Or how the Antinium were barely holding back the monsters. But the dead. Pawn closed his mandibles and looked down at the cooling bee.

“I let them down. They died to protect me. A quarter. They died, Erin. For me.”

“What? Who died, Pawn? Belgrade? Anand? Who?”

Erin leaned over Pawn, looking anxious, worried. That filled Pawn with something too, something bright, but also painful. He shook his head.

“Not them. My people. They...I put them on the walls.”

Erin and Ryoka exchanged a glance. Pawn knew he wasn’t making sense. He tried to explain as best he could.

“You were fighting? Monsters?”

“From where?”

Ryoka stared intently at Pawn, but he couldn't answer. He told Erin how he'd drawn the symbols of his dead Soldiers on the walls when he started shaking. He couldn't help it.

"I am sorry. It is just—"

"Don't be sorry."

Erin hugged him tightly, so tight that Pawn felt the shaking stop, as if she'd used a Skill. But her warmth was simple, plain. It was better than magic, more mysterious than a Skill. Erin stood up, looking angry and upset.

"I'm going to talk with Klbkch. I'm going to tell him he *can't* make Pawn and his Soldiers do this!"

"Wait a second, Erin—"

Ryoka rose, grabbing at her friend's arm, but Erin shook her off.

"Don't argue with me, Ryoka! This is wrong! Pawn, you sit right here. You don't have to worry about fighting and dying, okay? I'll take care of it."

She practically ran out of the door, despite Ryoka's attempts to stop her. Cursing, the girl returned to her seat and looked at Pawn.

"Damnit, I hope she doesn't try to storm the Hive."

"Revalantor Klbkch is most likely on duty as a [Guardsmen] in the city at the moment."

"Oh? Who's defending the Hive, then? I assume the monsters are still around."

Pawn froze. Would it be Belgrade? But no—he was resting.

"I—I do not know. Perhaps Xrn?"

But that didn't feel right. Who led the hive when Klbkch could not, and when Belgrade and Anand were out of commission? It had to be—

The Queen. Did she lead the Hive? She must. She must have ordered the Workers and Soldiers to do battle thousands of times before Belgrade and Anand had taken some of the burden away. She had to send them to

their deaths, over and over. How could she? How could she not care? Did she know?

The storm of emotions was hidden behind Pawn's face. Ryoka stared at him.

"I think Erin will get Klbkch to take your unit off the front lines. Erin's persuasive like that and Klbkch...will probably listen to her. Even if he wouldn't listen to anyone else."

Pawn shook his head.

"I wish she would not do that. Revalantor Klbkch...had his reasons for ordering my unit into combat."

Good ones too. He was right. Pawn's group of one hundred Soldiers had suffered least out of the groups assigned to combat, and his had fought in one of the most hotly contested areas. His Soldiers *were* stronger than normal ones. But they had died.

How could he ever ask the Soldiers to fight again? How could he face them? But Ryoka didn't seem concerned with that. She was staring at Pawn and clearing her throat. He looked at her. She drummed her fingers on the table for a moment.

"Look...Pawn. I've wanted to speak to you for a while now. Since Erin's gone, now's the best time. I know you're upset, but you and I have to speak now about your...beliefs."

Pawn froze. He looked cautiously at Ryoka.

"What do you mean by that?"

She met his eyes levelly.

"I mean, I heard from Erin about how she told you about Christianity. About...God. And I had a talk with Klbkch and he says you're a believer. And you have a class. Is that true?"

If she'd talked to Klbkch, then he could speak to her, right? Pawn hesitated, and then nodded. He lowered his voice, without knowing why. It seemed like something Ryoka would want.

"That is correct. I am a Level 6 [Acolyte]. I received the class after I...prayed and was told of religion and heaven by Erin."

Why did Ryoka freeze up at that? Her eyes flicked to Lyonette, who was arguing with Safry about a plate Mrsha had accidentally knocked over. Then she looked back at Pawn, seemingly worried.

“An [Acolyte]? Damn. Uh, has Klbkch told you why that’s not a good thing?”

Pawn nodded. Klbkch had indicated it was not, in action as well as word. He’d told Pawn not to speak of gods to anyone. After he’d tried to kill Pawn for knowing about gods in the first place.

“He has expressed his desire to keep such knowledge private. I have done so, and only told you of my class outside of my Hive. However, I do not understand the reason for his distrust of gods.”

“Yeah, well, that’s complicated. If he didn’t tell you, I don’t think I should either.”

Ryoka traced patterns on the table, thinking hard. She hesitated, and looked at Pawn again.

“I uh, can’t say why Pawn, but this faith business is trouble. Klbkch, your Revalantor, agrees with me, and so does your Queen, I think. So...why don’t you just stop praying? It...really doesn’t do much good. Or rather, there are other ways you can help your people.”

Pawn stared at Ryoka. He felt shocked, stunned by the words coming out of her mouth.

“Stop...praying? Stop believing?”

She nodded and leaned over the table.

“Look, it’s not something your people need. A god is important, sure... faith, hell it’s meaningful, but the people of this world have gotten along fine without one for this long. Can’t you, I don’t know, just forget about it?”

Just forget about it. Just forget about Heaven. Forget about god. Forget about—

Something blazed in Pawn. He closed his mandibles, leaned away from Ryoka. When he spoke, his grief was forgotten. It had been replaced by the anger of indignation.

“No.”

Ryoka sighed and scrubbed at her hair.

“Come on. Why do you need to believe? Like I said, it’s really dangerous if it spreads—”

“It is necessary for the Antinium.”

She looked blank.

“Why? Why would believing—”

“You do not know what it means to be Antinium.”

Pawn cut Ryoka off shortly. She did not understand. He tried to tell himself that. And then he realized that was it. She really didn’t understand. Pawn looked at Ryoka, who seemed to be growing more annoyed. She was ignorant.

“Look, I’m trying to be nice, but Klbkch and I agree—”

“What would you give someone with one day to live?”

Pawn stared at Ryoka. She blinked.

“Excuse me?”

“What would you give someone with exactly twenty four hours to live before they died? Someone who knew their death was imminent?”

She stared at him. But unlike Erin, she didn’t question Pawn’s words, but took the query at face value.

“One day? Well, I guess I’d give them what they always dreamed of. Time with their family if they have any, money to do what they wanted... uh, maybe a chance to—”

“No.”

She broke off.

“What?”

Pawn shook his head deliberately. She still did not understand. He spoke carefully, choosing each word to make her comprehend.

“You are misunderstanding my question. I said, what would you give someone who had one day to live? Not years. Not decades. One. Day. One

day total. Someone who came into existence and will die within hours of waking.”

Ryoka’s eyes widened.

“You mean—a Soldier? A Worker? One of the Antinium?”

“Yes.”

The word was bitter on Pawn’s mandibles. He broke off a leg of the dead Ashfire bee, stared at it as he spoke.

“You Humans live for years, do you not? In most cases, you live at least until you are ten, many twice that age. Some live for nearly a century. Other races live longer, others shorter. But the lifespan of an Antinium may be a single day. Or less.”

“You mean they’re born and are fully cognizant the instant they come out?”

Ryoka seemed fascinated, but she was *missing the point*. Pawn nodded.

“The instant a Soldier emerges, he is expected to fight and serve his Hive. He may be sent into battle minutes after he is born. What can he have in those minutes, if not faith that he is dying for a reason?”

“For his Hive, you mean. For his queen.”

“Yes. *But it is not enough*. If the Soldier lives, he will fight every day for his Hive. Fight and die, Ryoka Griffin. That is his fate. Fight and die. What can you give him? Money? He has nowhere to spend it. Family? He will never reproduce, and his brethren die with him. An experience? *He has never seen the sky*.”

The young woman sat across from Pawn, staring at him as if she were looking at something horrible or tragic. Pawn felt something surging in his body, something dark, but also...

“You tell me faith is not needed. I disagree. When Erin told me of God, of Heaven, it was important. It was *necessary*. Because what else can the Antinium cling to? What can I give the Soldiers who died for me, if not hope of a place to rest? What can I give a Soldier who will die in moments, if not faith? Tell me, Ryoka Griffin. Why is faith meaningless to the Antinium?”

She had no reply. She sat back, looking stunned, and then ashamed. When she did speak, minutes later, it was humbly.

“I’m wrong.”

Pawn nodded.

“Yes. You are.”

She nodded as well.

“I didn’t know about how the Antinium lived. I guessed, but...I’m sorry about that. I’d change it if I could, how your people live. And you’re right—religion is important. Especially to your people. I...think I’d forgotten that. If I ever knew. But it doesn’t change the fact that faith is dangerous in this world. Faith in a god is dangerous, Pawn. Can you understand that?”

He reached for his mug and drank slowly.

“I understand that you and Revalantor Klbkch fear Gods. You fear one of them. Are there living Gods in this world, then?”

Ryoka jumped and looked around. Pawn lowered his mug.

“It is not a difficult thing to surmise. But it is curious. I believe in Gods...but you and Revalantor Klbkch *know* one exists.”

“So you do believe.”

The young woman was intent on Pawn.

“Are you a believer in Christianity, then? Are you...spreading the word of the Bible?”

Pawn paused. He shook his head.

“I believe in Jesus Christ. I believe he was born of the Virgin Mary. I believe he suffered under Pontius Pilate. I believe he was buried. I believe he descended into hell and returned. I believe he is a God. But I believe he is not *my* God.”

Ryoka’s jaw dropped. She struggled for words.

“How? If you can believe...how?”

Pawn shrugged.

“It is simple. He is not my God. He is yours. When God created the earth, he created animals and Humans, the earth, the sky and stars and sea. But he did not create the Antinium, Ryoka Griffin. I know this. Because we created ourselves.”

“Oh.”

“Indeed. Your God cannot be ours. No matter how much we wish for it. Thus, I believe. I am an [Acolyte]. I have faith.”

“But how can you be if—”

“I believe in the Antinium. I believe in Heaven. I believe there is an afterlife, that miracles are possible, and I believe in Gods. Just as I believe the Antinium have none.”

Pawn said it simply, and spoke the truth. He believed. He believed the Soldiers who had died would not be swept away into ash and dust. He had to believe in that, because he could not trust a God to do it for him.

“I don’t know what to say.”

Ryoka seemed breathless, caught between laughter and tears, incredulity and wonder. She shook her head, half-smiling.

“If I could bring you back to my world and introduce you to the Pope, or the Dalai Lama, or...or...a Jehovah’s Witness...I can’t do this. I’m not qualified to tell you anything.”

She looked at Pawn, a bit sadly, regretfully.

“I don’t believe, Pawn. I don’t, although I think there is a...a God in this world. But I would refuse to believe in him or her or it. And yet...I can’t tell you you’re wrong. I think you’re right to believe. I’m just worried.”

“Because belief is dangerous.”

“Of course.”

Ryoka Griffin sighed. She seemed old, tired. She looked at the ceiling as Mrsha slunk by her feet, chastised by Maran. Ryoka bent down to pet Mrsha, and the Gnoll stared up at her and Pawn. A child. But not a dog.

At last, Ryoka reached a decision. She took a breath and nodded, and then looked at Pawn.

“I think...yeah, I think I should tell you all about it. It’s only right, and it might help. I’ll tell Klbkch the same.”

“Tell me what?”

Ryoka smiled crookedly.

“Religions, Pawn. Not just one. Erin told you about Christianity, right? Well, I’ll fill in any gaps she might have missed and...let’s call it context. I read the Bible back to front. And I know...well, I know a bit about other religions, too. Buddhism, Sikhism, Shinto, Zoroastrianism...not everything, but I can tell you more than Erin did. If you’ll let me, I’d like to tell you about other religions, the good and the bad.”

Pawn looked at her. For the first time that day, his heart lifted. His mandibles parted, and raised in a slight smile.

“Truly?”

“If you’re going to be the first religious Antinium...you might as well be the most informed. Sure. Let’s start with Christianity.”

“I know much of what Erin has told me.”

“Yeah, I know. But did you know Christianity is only one interpretation of, well, everything? It’s part of what’s known as the Abrahamic religions—that is to say, Abrahamism. That encompasses all religions who worship the God of Abraham. But there are many religions within that definition, who believe different things. For instance, there are two other major religions—Islam and Judaism—that believe Jesus Christ was not the Son of God.”

Pawn’s mandibles opened wide, the equivalent of Ryoka’s jaw dropping. She nodded, smiling.

“For instance, in the Islamic faith, they use the Quran, another holy book instead of the Bible and believe that Muhammad was the last of God’s prophets. Now, they differ from Christianity on several fundamental issues, but have several similarities, beginning with...”

The skies opened. The snow stopped. The world warmed, and Pawn felt himself standing on the edge of the sky, looking past the horizon at

something like stars. It was something vast, something distant—

But all so familiar. He wanted to reach out and touch it. That was how he felt as he listened to Ryoka. She told him about Islam, about Judaism and the difference between Catholics and Protestants, Mormons and Quakers.

And then she told him about what each religion did, how they differed. Erin had told Pawn about people eating Jesus in the form of bread—Ryoka explained the difference between transubstantiation and consubstantiation. But what was far more important than terms was how each religion worked.

“They eat braided bread instead of wafers?”

“Braided bread. Yes. That would be...*challah*. I think that’s what it’s called.”

Ryoka frowned, nodding to herself.

“It’s more of a food than wafers, you understand. The Jewish people will eat it on special occasions, not just before communion.”

Pawn nodded. Ideas were flashing through his head like the stars in the sky.

“Do you know how to make it?”

“Make it?”

Ryoka blinked, astounded. Pawn nodded seriously.

“I should like to try some. And...yes, perhaps I can speak to Lyonette or Erin about obtaining honey. It is not the same as wine, but I believe it may be cheaper and more palatable to the Antinium. A tiny bit of bread will not upset our systems.”

“Wait. You want bread and honey? For a communion?”

The Asian girl was blinking and frowning.

“I thought you didn’t believe in the Bible. Why adopt a religious service like it?”

Pawn looked blankly at Ryoka and shook his head sadly. She was so knowledgeable, but she did not understand.

“Because it *is* a religious service. Clearly, there is merit in it. So the Antinium must have the same. Not the exact same of course, since we will

not worship that God. But it is a good idea.”

Ryoka was doing the open-mouthed thing again. She spoke slowly.

“You’re going to...steal the ideas of Judaism? Wait, not steal, but copy?”

Pawn nodded as if it were the most obvious thing in the world.

“Of course. And I would like to hear of non-Abrahamic religions, please. If Christianity is not the only religion, then I must hear of them all. All Human religions. Because there is so much wonder in the stories Erin told me, of God and his people. Surely there must be similar wonders in every religion. I wish to hear of it all. So I can take what the Antinium can use.”

She blinked at him. And then laughed.

“The Antinium really don’t mind about plagiarism, do they?”

Pawn lifted his mandibles in a smile.

“I do not know what that word means. But we do not shy away from copying what is glorious, what works.”

Ryoka shrugged, cracking her fingers together and making Mrsha jump underneath the table.

“Well then. I’d better get to work.”

In the end, she spoke for two more hours, until Erin got back. By that point Ryoka was drinking honey water for her throat, as hoarse as she was. But Pawn had heard many good things. Chiefly among them were a few ideas.

“A shrine. Shinto. Buddhist prayer beads. And a Catholic...what did you call it?”

“A censor.”

“Hey Pawn, I talked to Klbkch!”

Erin looked triumphant, but Pawn and Ryoka didn't glance twice at her.

"Thank you, Erin Solstice."

"Yeah, thanks Erin. Wait, why do you want a censer, Pawn?"

Crestfallen, Erin stared at Pawn and edged slowly over to the table as they kept talking.

"A censer is a powerful tool, or so it seems to me. It is different from a cross in that it has a physical presence."

"From the incense."

"Yes. I would like to have one, possibly on a chain as you described. That would be very convenient."

"Uh...technically, that's a thurible. If a censer has chains, it's called a thurible. Sorry."

Ryoka looked embarrassed to have contributed the detail, but Pawn nodded his head gravely.

"I will commit that to memory. Do you know how to make one?"

"Make one? Hell, it's not hard...the trick would be describing it. Look, if you've got some parchment and a quill I could—"

"I've got one!"

Erin leapt up, surprising Ryoka and Pawn. She ran into the kitchen and came back with the items.

"Here! Draw!"

Ryoka carefully sketched out a censer, and Pawn noted the holes on the top and bottom where the burnt incense's fragrance would drift outwards. Yes, it was just what he'd imagined.

"I would like to have one. If you will assist me with the plans, I believe I will go to a [Blacksmith] and have one commissioned."

"If you like..."

"Hey! What about me? I could build one for Pawn!"

Erin interrupted the two, beaming. They looked at her incredulously.

“You could do it, Erin?”

Ryoka was skeptical. Erin blew out her cheeks, exasperated.

“I *do* have [Advanced Crafting], Pawn. I could build parts of my inn myself but...well, that’s a lot of work. The least I can do is help you build a censer.”

“Thurible. This one has chains.”

Ryoka grinned as Pawn corrected Erin. Erin rolled her eyes and then looked at Ryoka.

“So Ryoka...what does a thurible look like?”

To Pawn’s surprise, there were all the parts Erin needed at hand already. The censer was made, according to Ryoka, to allow the incense to burn and waft out of the container. It required holes, in short, which would also make it ‘holey’ according to Erin. That was apparently a joke that neither Ryoka nor Pawn laughed at.

To build the first prototype of a censer, Erin took two colanders which had been used to strain spaghetti, and put them together. She added a basin to catch the incense and ash that would fall from the bottom colander, and added a chain around the top.

“What do you think? Is that it?”

Ryoka eyed the impromptu thurible skeptically. Erin had used string to tie the basin of the colander to the other basin, and she’d put a coal and some sticks of ground-up cinnamon into the colander. Now she picked up the entire affair with another bit of string and swung the censer around gently. Smoke began to drift out of the holes on the top and bottom, bringing a sweet smell that Pawn inhaled slowly.

The Runner coughed as Erin wafted the thurible at her. She waved smoke away from her face.

“It’s...sort of like a thurible, Erin. The real thing would be smaller, and less...unwieldy. Are you sure you have...[Advanced Crafting]?”

Erin glared at Ryoka as Pawn inspected the thurible.

“Hey, I don’t have [Advanced Metalworking] or whatever you need. And I don’t know what a thurible looks like!”

“Well, it’s a good start.”

Ryoka eyed the contraption with quite a bit of reserve, but Pawn shook his head as he carefully lifted the thurible up and examined it. He addressed Erin.

“I believe I can commission a smaller version later, and I will return the colander to you at another time. But for now...this is perfect.”

She beamed at him, and then tugged Ryoka away to whisper to her.

“Psst, Ryoka. What’s a colander?”

“A strainer, Erin. You’ve been using it every time to drain pasta.”

“*Oh*. Why don’t they just call it a strainer?”

Ryoka sighed, and didn’t bother replying.

By this point, the hours had worn on and it was approaching dinner. Pawn sat at his table, feeling better. A thurible. And there were all sorts of things Ryoka had mentioned. This might help—

He paused. It would not help the Soldiers. They would still fight and die. His prayers...could not change fate.

And yet Erin had done just that. They wouldn’t have to fight! There was relief in Pawn’s heart as he considered that, and joy as he thought of sharing the thurible with the Soldiers. The other religious artifacts Ryoka had mentioned would be of interest to them too, surely. Perhaps Pawn could conduct a mass? They could enjoy themselves.

And no one would die.

He barely saw Erin get intercepted on her way to the kitchen, but Pawn’s attention was attracted when Maran, one of the [Barmaids] began pointing out the six water barrels stacked up against the wall. He heard Erin exclaiming over them, and then her cheerful voice.

“Hey, that isn’t a bad idea! It might save some time...sure, why not? We can try it out tomorrow as well. Thanks, Maran!”

She hurried back to Ryoka and Pawn.

“Guess what, guys? Maran had this great idea to buy water barrels from Celum! We can just get them filled up each day and it’ll be a lot easier than

going out for water, she says! Isn't that cool?"

Pawn nodded obediently, having no input on water barrels. But sitting across from him, Ryoka frowned.

"How much would that cost, Erin?"

"Oh...I dunno. Maran didn't say."

"It seems like a waste to me."

"Yeah, but if it saves time—"

"Erin!"

Someone hurried across the floor towards them. Lyonette. Pawn sat up upon seeing her. He opened his mandibles to greet Lyonette. He had a lot of affection for all the times she had helped him, but she was focused on Erin.

"Erin, did you tell Maran you're going to buy *more* water barrels tomorrow?"

"Yeah, don't worry about it Lyonette! It's a great idea, don't you think? Maran told me she thought it would really help the inn, so I—"

"She didn't do it to help the inn! She did it because she was too afraid to go outside and haul water!"

The anger and frustration in Lyonette's voice made Pawn sit up. She was furious, but hissing at Erin while the other workers served the Gold-rank adventurers filing into the inn. Erin froze. Her eyes swiveled to Maran, who was busy flirting with an impassive Ulrien.

"But she said—"

"I *asked* them to get water from the stream and they both said no. Maran took money from your jar and went to buy six barrels! It must have cost at least twelve silver coins, and we could have gotten fresher water if we'd hauled it ourselves!"

The entire story came out quickly, Erin blinking in shock and Ryoka grimacing. When Lyonette was done and breathing heavily, Erin nodded seriously.

"Okay, that was wrong. Taking money and not listening to you? Yeah, I'll tell them they can't do that again, Lyon."

Decisively, Erin walked past Lyonette. The girl looked relieved, but that relief changed to panic in a moment when Erin spoke.

“Hey Maran, Safry! Lyonette told me that earlier, you two didn’t want to haul water. But you said...”

The two [Barmaids] blinked and came over as Erin began to talk with them, frowning hard. Meanwhile, Lyonette was staring at Erin as the [Innkeeper] pointed back several times to her as she talked to the other [Barmaids].

Lyonette hurried away, taking over serving drinks while Erin scolded Maran and Safry. Ryoka and Pawn looked and saw the two barmaids were glaring daggers at Lyonette as Erin spoke with them. Ryoka covered her face.

“That moron. You don’t dress down workers in public like that. And she *told* them to their faces that Lyonette was...”

She was grinding her teeth together. Pawn looked at her quizzically.

“I do not understand the full context of what is happening, Ryoka. Is Erin’s hiring new employees objectionable to you?”

“No, but it looks like there’s a problem. It’s a staffing issue and Erin’s making a mistake. At least...she might be. Lyonette could be lying, or exaggerating the problem, or there’s something else at work here.”

Ryoka chewed at her lip distractedly. Pawn listened obediently, since she seemed to know what she was talking about.

“No one’s impartial in a pissing match...and office drama is always ugly, so why not [Barmaid] drama. Damn it.”

She thought for a second and then looked at him.

“Hey Pawn, how much do you trust Lyonette? I mean, how much would you trust what she said? One hundred percent?”

Pawn didn’t have to think to answer.

“She fed my Soldiers and I. She gave us honey, and offered us food when no one else would. She helped paint my Soldiers. She gave them respite and shelter. I do not know Safry and Maran. But I would trust anything Lyonette said.”

Ryoka nodded grimly.

“That’s what I thought. She’s changed. And Maran and Safry, well, they did come from Agnes’ inn...maybe I should do something about this.”

Pawn had no idea what that meant. But he felt relieved and tired. It was over. His Soldiers were safe. He could pray, and know they would be safe. Prayer was good, but knowing was better. He sagged in his seat.

“I am going to sleep.”

Ryoka blinked at him.

“Wait, what?”

But it was too late. Pawn, exhausted by fighting and grief, slowly drifted off into slumber. All would be well. He believed that.

His dreams were still filled with death. The Antinium he held in his arms had no paint on his body.

But he was still dead all the same.

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4.15 L

When Lyonette woke up on the third day, she didn't want to get out of bed. For the first time she felt *uneasy* about working.

It was all wrong. Everything last night was supposed to go well! Erin was supposed to kick out Maran and Safry, or make it so they wouldn't cause trouble. That was all Lyon wanted. She just wanted the other two to do their jobs without complaining, or refusing to do something.

But instead Erin had told them *Lyonette* was the one who had an issue with them and just lectured them! Lyonette had felt the other two [Barmaid]'s eyes on her all night. And when they'd left...

Lyonette was relieved to find it was Ishkr and Drassi who had been selected for the morning rotation. She greeted the two with a smile.

"Hello Drassi, Ishkr!"

"Hey Lyonette! Hey cute Mrsha! What're we doing today?"

"Hrr. Morning Lyonette. Should I fetch water today to start with?"

It was strange, but Lyonette knew what to do. It was easy to assign Drassi to wait the tables since she was naturally inclined to it, and Ishkr actually seemed to *prefer* the trek to get water and clean the outhouses.

In the case of the outhouses of course, the trick wasn't so much to empty them, which was a horrible thought to contemplate, but toss down some hay and dirt, hang some scented herbs up, clean the wood if it needed it, and so on. If it got full...well, Lyonette had spoken seriously to Erin about that and the solution Erin had come up with was find some kind of spell to blast the hole deeper or vaporize the mess.

Regardless, it was a joy to work with the two because Lyonette just had to tell Drassi to wait the tables, and give Ishkr a list of things that needed doing and they did them. It left Lyon with time to play with Mrsha, help out Erin in the kitchen, and in general, relax.

But the bowel-clenching and the stiff-muscles came as soon as Lyonette checked the schedule Erin had drawn up and realized she'd be with Safry

and Maran for the rest of the day. It was the weekend, so the two Human [Barmaids] would be coming in to help deal with the increased traffic soon enough.

Lyonette prayed nothing bad would happen, but she remembered the look the two had given her. She consoled herself with a bit of righteous anger. It was *their* fault they'd refused to get water and bought things with Erin's coin.

Trouble started when Safry came in for her first shift, just before noon. At first things were, well, not ideal, but workable. Erin had left once again, mainly to talk seriously with Ryoka about 'stuff' that happened to include the words 'bicycle', 'light bulb', and 'antibiotics', all of which were a mystery to Lyonette.

Despite that however, Safry didn't antagonize Lyonette. She just ignored the girl. She had a job, and Lyonette had a job. All they had to do was do it and not get in each other's way.

Still, there was no denying that Lyonette clenched her jaw and a little spasm of intense dislike flared up in her stomach every time she met Safry's eyes. It was an unpleasant feeling, but Lyon could live with it. For today, at least.

No, the problem came from Mrsha. Lyonette hadn't realized it, but the young Gnoll was still a very intelligent child, for all she didn't speak. She could read subtext, and probably smell it as well. She'd had her own brushes with Safry and Maran, mainly getting in their way, and she knew Lyonette didn't like them.

That was probably why she started her mischief. Mrsha would leap up onto a chair or table right after Safry had finished cleaning it, or pause to get in the woman's way while she worked. The first few times Lyonette caught her and scolded her, but to no real effect. Mrsha just did it again, until Lyonette threatened to put her upstairs in her room.

"Can't you control her?"

Safry snapped at Lyonette after the last warning. Mrsha's eyes narrowed, but Lyonette bit back her retort and apologized for her.

The door to Celum opened and Erin and Ryoka came through. Erin was laughing happily and holding something mossy in her hand. Lyon recoiled from it, but apparently it was a useful...moss?

“It might work. If Octavia’s done her job, it’s got potential. I didn’t know you could boost the growth of fungi with mana potions, but Erin, be careful. We don’t know how other species react to it, and there might be side effects—”

“Got it! I got it! But if I try just a bit on Brunkr—okay, I’ll be careful! Don’t glare! And we’re back on time like you said.”

“Yeah.”

Ryoka glanced around the inn, looking at first Lyonette, then Safry. She frowned.

“Anyone seen Pisces?”

“I think he’s still sleeping in the basement. Or practicing magic.”

The [Mage] often woke up late, still poring over the spellbook Ryoka had bought or mumbling about proper craftsmanship and magic. Ryoka nodded. She went down into the basement and came up in a minute dragging Pisces. She shoved him into a seat and had a word with him.

She vanished after that. Pisces left too, grumbling about finding the rest of the Horns of Hammerad, and Erin was long gone into the city to give the mold—it wasn’t a moss—to Brunkr for some reason. That left Lyonette alone, well, not alone, but with Safry.

It went well for five minutes. Then Lyonette noticed Mrsha leaping up onto a table in the corner. She seemed intent on something, although there was nothing there. Someone had probably spilled a drink, but the Gnoll kept sniffing and then backing away.

And she happened to be right in the way of Safry as she was collecting dishes.

“Out of the way, Mrsha.”

Mrsha glanced up at Safry, but didn’t move. She circled the table and Lyonette called out to Safry, exasperated.

“Just leave her. If she stays there, she won’t bother anyone.”

Safry ignored her. She pointed down at the floor, and raised her voice, as if speaking to a dog.

“Down. *Down.*”

A glance up, and then Mrsha deliberately turned her back on Safry. The [Barmaid] lost her patience. She *pushed* Mrsha off the table and onto the floor.

The Gnoll landed with a yelp. Lyonette dropped the dust rag she was holding as Drassi and Ishkr looked up. Safry glared down at Mrsha.

“Down. Understand?”

The Gnoll cub stared up at her. She wasn’t injured from the small fall, but she was hurt, and surprised. Lyonette lost her temper.

“*Stop that!*”

She advanced on Safry, hands balled into fists. Safry whirled and snapped at her.

“If you’d control her better, I wouldn’t have to teach her proper manners!”

“She’s just a child! She can play wherever she wants. And if you push her again I will make sure you don’t push *anything* again.”

Lyonette was ready to do violence, and Safry was clearly ready for a fight. She advanced, but Drassi leapt forwards and Ishkr dragged Lyonette back.

“Hrr. Hold still Lyonette. It is not the place to fight, no? Hold!”

He was far stronger than she was, even with [Lesser Strength]. Lyon struggled a bit in his grasp, but then Mrsha was between her and Safry. The other [Barmaid] struggled out of Drassi’s grip, and Ishkr let Lyonette go after a moment.

“Keep her out of the way.”

“Touch her and—”

Lyonette went to Mrsha, still glaring at Safry. She told Mrsha to play upstairs for today, and the Gnoll agreed, sensing the air in the room. But that was it.

Lyonette was going to kill Safry.

She'd grab one of the seed cores Erin kept in the kitchen and shove it down the other woman's mouth. Or she'd stab her from behind. Or—

These were the thoughts that filled Lyon's head as she began working and people began coming in for the midday rush. Murder. Violence. They were comforting feelings, even if she couldn't act on them.

But she would do *something*. Oh yes. Erin would hear about this at the very least! Lyon wasn't working another *day* with Safry! Or Maran! When Erin came back she'd—

Erin did not come back, busy as she was with Brunkr and molds. But Maran came in for her shift soon after, and then trouble really started. Safry told Maran what had happened, and as far as the inn was concerned, there were now two mortal enemies sharing the same roof. Well, three mortal enemies but two sides.

Safry went back to the table Mrsha had been on, cleaning it and muttering about Gnoll hair everywhere. She was just going over to wring the cloth in the bucket when her feet went out from under her.

She'd tripped. Something had struck her foot, and Safry landed hard on the ground. She looked back, enraged, thinking it was Lyonette—but the girl was across the room, teaching Ishkr where Erin kept her supply of emergency potions.

Suspiciously, Safry looked around. There was only an empty chair next to a table. Angry, having no one but herself to blame and angrier still that that was the case Safry stood up and got back to work. She ended up tripping three more times throughout the day, each time when she passed by that table.

[Acolyte Level 8!]

[Skill – Mass Prayer obtained!]

Pawn woke up with the memory of those words ringing in his mind. He smiled as he sat up in the darkness. In his four hands he still held the thurible, missing an ember and proper incense, but perfectly workable.

He was leveling. He was on the right path. And his Soldiers would not die.

He was also in the wrong place. Pawn had thought he was in his dirt cubicle, but instead he was in a dark room, and there was a blanket covering him! He looked around, and realized he was in a corner of the Wandering Inn's basement.

He'd fallen asleep here, and slept the night away! Dread filled Pawn and he scrambled up the stairs.

"Pawn!"

Lyonette greeted him with a strained smile, but Pawn was in too much of a hurry to notice.

"I am sorry to intrude. Is Erin here? I wish to thank her."

"No, I think she's out."

"Ah. In that case I must go. I must report in to my Hive!"

He fled, hurrying down towards Liscor. Even if Klbkch did not order him into combat duty, he still had to attend a debriefing meeting with Klbkch about his Soldiers' performance.

But he *wouldn't* be ordered into combat, right? Erin had said. She'd *promised*. His Soldiers would be safe. They wouldn't die.

Part of Pawn's dream of last night nagged at him. He'd been holding a dead Antinium, one without paint. He banished the memory. That was just a dream. He would be—

The Hive was busy as ever. Pawn navigated the streams of Workers and Soldiers, looking for Klbkch.

"Revalantor Klbkch. Have you seen him? Where is he?"

Workers pointed him onwards, towards one of the areas closest to the dungeon. Apprehensively, Pawn hurried down that way, pausing to let

Soldiers rush by, alert for monsters. But he found Klbkch a good ways away from the actual front.

Because Klbkch was wounded.

Pawn halted as he suddenly came to the Revalantor. Klbkch was surrounded by a wall of twenty Soldiers, all injured, some missing limbs. Klbkch was leaning against a wall, bleeding profusely from his side.

Something had torn it open. The Antinium dropped one of his silvery swords and was fumbling with a healing potion. Pawn rushed over as Klbkch got the stopper out.

“Pawn.”

The other Antinium had noticed Pawn’s arrival. He parted his mandibles weakly as Pawn stared at the green fluid rushing down his side. He had a deep cut down one shoulder as well, a blow that had split his chitin, and more, smaller cuts down his legs.

“A moment.”

Klbkch poured the healing potion over himself, carefully sprinkling it without wasting the precious liquid. The wounds closed quickly. Klbkch staggered, and then looked at Pawn. He stoppered the nearly-empty potion bottle with one hand and put it in his belt pouch.

“Pawn. I was wondering as to your location. You spent the night outside of the Hive.”

Pawn was still staring at Klbkch, at where the wounds had been. They’d closed just like that. In an instant. Of course, that was how healing potions worked, but now you couldn’t tell Klbkch had been injured. You’d never be able to tell, come to that. So long as he didn’t die, he could have been fighting a moment ago and you’d never notice...

“Yes, I—I fell asleep in the inn. My deepest apologies. I had not rested since my assignment and—”

“It is fine.”

Klbkch cut him off shortly. The Antinium hauled himself up and snapped at the Soldiers.

“Return to battle.”

They immediately dispersed, running back down the corridor. Pawn could hear a monster screaming in the distance. That left Klbkch and Pawn alone. The Revalantor nodded at Pawn.

“I was visited by Erin Solstice yesterday. She had words for me regarding your deployment.”

“Yes, I—”

Suddenly Pawn’s jubilation was gone. He felt ashamed. But Klbkch shook his head.

“Her concerns had merit. I agreed with her proposal. Your unit displayed extreme efficacy in battle, despite the dangers. Your losses... depleted a valuable resource to the Hive. In light of that, and remarks made by Xrn—”

His mandibles lowered in an Antinium grimace.

“Your unit may resume patrolling above. There is no need to report for combat duty in the Hive in the foreseeable future. We will handle matters below now that Xrn has agreed to lend her abilities when needed.”

Pawn nodded numbly.

“I understand.”

Klbkch nodded as well. He straightened and picked up the other sword he’d dropped.

“Continue training your Soldiers, Pawn. Do not worry about Belgrade or Anand. They will recover. In the meantime, I will coordinate my efforts with my Queen and Xrn to maintain the defense of the Hive.”

He turned away. Pawn watched him stride back towards the sound of battle. He wanted to say something, anything. But he couldn’t.

Suddenly, Pawn realized a hole had opened back up under his feet. He’d been thinking for so long about what had happened. He’d led his Soldiers in a battle, something he thought Klbkch wouldn’t do, couldn’t understand.

But of course the Revalantor fought. He had put *himself* on the line. And the Workers and Soldiers—were still fighting. Why would that stop? It was just Pawn’s unit that had been granted a reprieve, safety. Suddenly, Pawn felt as useless as before. No. Worse.

What was he doing?

What had he done?

Trouble had two names. Maran, and Safry. Trouble also had a Human's face, and was multiplied about two dozen times.

Suddenly, a huge amount of Humans had come through Octavia's door into the inn. It had happened around one, and although it had surprised Lyonette, it hadn't come as a shock to Maran or Safry. Now these Humans laughed and ate and did all the things guests were supposed to do...but they were Human.

And Lyon had the feeling that was just the way Safry and Maran liked it.

"I had a word with some of my friends and regular customers. I told them they should eat here. It'll balance out the inn."

"You mean add more Humans."

Lyonette glared as she confronted Maran over the issue. The [Barmaid] laughed.

"So what? They're customers. Erin will be happy. Anyways, they're guests, and probably hungry. You can take their orders. I'm going on lunch and so is Safry."

"What?"

Ishkr and Drassi had already gone on their break, but suddenly Maran was finding a seat and Safry was bringing over some of Erin's magically fresh food, heated up and piping hot. Lyonette protested.

"You can't do that!"

"We get a break. That's the Innkeeper's Guild's policy and Erin agreed. We're having lunch now. We'll be done in thirty minutes. You can handle things until then."

Suddenly, there were over twenty hungry people all demanding drinks and food at the same time. It was like the bad old days, but worse, because there were two [Barmaids] having a grand time watching Lyonette hurry around.

“I’m going to kill them. I’m going to feed Safry to a Rock Crab and let Maran walk into an Ashfire Bee hive...”

Lyonette was cursing under her breath, struggling to open another keg when someone held it steady for her.

“Don’t bother with monsters. Let’s just push them down the outhouse hole and put the lid down.”

Drassi grinned toothily at Lyonette as the girl stared at her. She offered a mug as Lyonette finally got a dark, amber-colored liquid to come forth and the girl hurriedly filled it.

“Thanks. I know you’re on your break.”

“Don’t mind a thing. I had to help out once I saw those fleshbags lazing about. Not you, them, I mean. I don’t know why Erin hired them.”

Lyonette made a face. She hurried over to the table and spoke as she grabbed the other two mugs Drassi was quickly filling.

“I think they thought they’d be working a lot less over here. And they’re not used to Drakes or Gnolls. I wasn’t—I learned, but it took time.”

“Think they’ll quit?”

“I’m going to talk to Erin. They’d better quit, or I’ll kill them myself after Safry bullying Mrsha.”

Lyonette’s face was a thunderhead. Drassi nodded in complete agreement, and then flicked her tail to the two [Barmaids].

“I might quit. Because if I have to listen to them ask me which Drake is which when one’s an old guy and the other one’s barely *hatched*—”

“Don’t do that! Erin will sort things out.”

“I hope so.”

“Hrr. She had better. Or I might take up your offer with the outhouse as well.”

Someone else came to join them. Ishkr had some food ready for the Humans. He nodded awkwardly at Lyon, not as comfortable as Drassi at socializing.

“I am not cleaning myself each time I get wet walking through snow. I do not smell. *I* have a good sense of smell, and it is not problematic.”

“You smell wonderful.”

Lyonette smiled at him and got a wide grin in response. She felt better after that moment, and once the Humans were fed and given something to drink, she had a chance to have a short break herself.

The knowledge that Drassi and Ishkr felt like she did was a relief. It meant Lyonette wasn't prejudiced, that she was right, and that Maran and Safry had better watch themselves around the outhouses from now on. But it didn't solve the problem.

More guests arrived from Liscor. Erin's inn was developing a reputation as a hangout for adventurers, and also as the only place you could get good, cheap honey, aside from buying it from a certain Gnoll. Lyonette hadn't gone on a run to the Ashfire Bee hive in a while, and she worried she might run out.

But there were bigger problems to deal with at the moment. Drakes and Gnolls had come into the inn, some to play chess, others to enjoy an inn not completely full to the rafters, as many inns were in Liscor at the moment. Some wanted to go through to Celum. In any event, the inn was bustling before the sun had yet to fall far in the sky.

By now there was an invisible line across the inn. Maran and Safry circulated the tables where the Humans sat, chatting, laughing with them, while Lyonette, Ishkr and Drassi tried to cover all tables equally. But because the two Human [Barmaids] were focused only on half of the room, the non-Human staff and Lyonette had to focus more on their side. And the guests noticed.

They weren't idiots. And they had eyes. More than a few Drakes glared and some of the Gnolls sniffed and muttered quietly under their breaths, words only they and the other Gnolls could hear, which made Ishkr bare his teeth.

“Hey yo!”

Erin came back at the best and worst time possible. The best time because things were *really* heating up and every hand was needed. Safry and Maran’s pull for humanity had resulted in more people coming through via the group effect—if everyone was here, something good had to be happening—and that was on top of a weekend crowd!

It was also bad because Lyonette didn’t have a chance to pull her aside and talk about Safry and Maran. Oh, but it was going to happen soon! At any moment! As soon as she got more water, filled a few drinks, served five plates of piping hot pepper Corusdeer steaks—

“Drassi, you serve drinks, Ishkr, can you see if we have more of the Fireshot kegs in the basement? Safry, I need you to serve the Drakes. Just memorize where they’re sitting and—”

Lyonette was ordering everyone around, backed up by the knowledge that Erin was watching. However, Safry balked when she realized Lyonette hadn’t given herself a task at this busiest point.

“What are you going to do? I’ve got my hands full!”

Lyonette pointed to the stairs where she’d seen a furry white Gnoll head giving her imploring looks.

“I’ve got to feed Mrsha. She’s hungry and she needs a snack.”

“Her? Let her wait! Half of the room has an order.”

That was a good suggestion, a decent one. And because it came from Safry, Lyonette refused to consider it.

“I’ll be back in ten minutes.”

“You can’t just—”

“Hey, what’s the problem?”

For the first time, their argument had attracted Erin’s attention. Or it would be more accurate to say, this was the first time she’d been in the inn while a disagreement took place. And it was hard for Erin to miss the two [Barmaids] scowling at each other as the room heaved with work to be done.

Lyon opened her mouth to explain, but Safry beat her to it.

“Erin, Lyonette told me she’s going upstairs to take a break!”

Erin’s mouth opened. Lyon was faster.

“To feed Mrsha!”

“Oh, well then—”

“She can do that later, surely. And she’s been giving us orders all day!”

“Why’s that—”

“I’ve been *trying* to work with Safry and Maran, but they—”

“We haven’t been the ones letting that Gnoll run around—”

Safry was jabbing a finger at Lyon and Lyonette was trying to speak to Erin and butt Safry out of the conversation. Erin looked helplessly between the two and then raised her voice.

“*Enough!*”

The entire inn went silent. It felt as though someone had clapped a huge hand over Lyon’s mouth, knocking all the words she’d wanted to say back in. Erin looked around.

“Oops. Sorry everyone. I uh, may have used a Skill. [Crowd Control]. You know. Sorry about that.”

And then in the silence she turned back to Lyonette and Safry. And folded her arms. Lyonette gulped, because Erin was looking unusually *peev*ed.

“Okay, what’s this about? Why is Lyonette giving orders so bad? Safry first.”

Was there a flash of triumph in Safry’s eyes? Did her speaking first mean she’d get more of a say? Fear overruled hot anger and determination to be proven right in Lyonette’s bowels.

“Lyonette’s a lower level than we are. But she acts as if she’s in charge while you’re gone.”

Erin nodded.

“Right.”

She paused.

“So?”

Safry faltered.

“We’re higher level! Both Maran and I are twice Lyonette’s level—”

“Okay, I get it. And Lyonette?”

Erin turned to Lyonette, cutting Safry off. Lyonette suddenly felt afraid. She couldn’t just list off all the things Safry and Maran had done, not with everyone watching! But it was now or never. She took a deep breath, and steeled herself.

“Maran and Safry don’t listen to my orders. They prefer serving Humans, and take more breaks than they should. I don’t think I should be in charge—”

Something in Lyonette squeezed tightly on that last word. That wasn’t what she should say. No, that was what part of her wanted to say, but another part, a part of her that was royalty, rebelled.

“—Actually, I do think I should be in charge. I know what’s best, and I think Maran and Safry need to listen to what I say.”

Both Safry and Erin stared at Lyon, surprised by her statement. Lyon was surprised too, and worried, but another part of her knew she had spoken her mind, and spoken the truth as she saw it.

In the silence, all eyes fell on Erin. She seemed used to that, and took only a minute before nodding to herself.

“Okay, I’m resolving this. Safry, Maran, Ishkr, Drassi, and Lyonette, everyone listen up.”

All the staff looked at Erin, worry reflected in some measure across every face. Erin met their eyes and then turned.

“Lyonette? Uh...she’s in charge.”

Relief followed vindication followed vindictive joy in seconds. But Lyonette didn’t have time to smile before Maran burst out across the room.

“But we’re higher level. That’s not right!”

Erin turned towards Maran, and Lyon saw she was frowning.

“Higher level? So what? That might be how you people do things, but not where I come from. Lyonette *ran* this inn while I was away. She’s got more experience.”

“But she—she hasn’t worked half as long as a [Barmaid] as we have!”

Safry burst out, but Erin was unmoved. She pointed at the floor.

“Yeah, but Lyonette’s been working *here* longer. She knows what’s important, and I trust her. So...you and Maran listen to her now, okay? Problem solved!”

Erin smiled and clapped her hands together. No one else moved. Safry and Maran exchanged looks, and then Safry sighed.

“Okay. I quit.”

“What?”

Erin and Lyon stared at her, wide-eyed. Safry threw up her hands.

“I’m not dealing with Lyonette! She’s impossible and I—I deserve better treatment than this! I’ve worked at Agnes’ inn for over *eight years*, and I know my job better than some arrogant girl who thinks she can push me and Maran around.”

“That’s right. If Safry quits, I quit too!”

Maran spoke up. Lyonette felt the purest element of rage settle into her soul. She felt she could harness that fury into some kind of incredibly destructive spell, it was that fierce. *She* was the problem? She was pushing them around?

But what was worse than the two [Barmaid]’s stupid dramatic exit and accusations was that it worked on Erin. She looked worried and chased after Safry as the other woman walked towards the door, but not too fast that Erin couldn’t block her way.

“Hold on Safry, let’s talk about this.”

“Either Lyonette stops or—”

“Okay, okay, let’s talk about this. Why don’t you take a break and—”

“Go ahead and leave. It’s for the best.”

Someone spoke up across the room. Heads turned as Ryoka appeared at a table, as if by magic. The watching guests murmured as she stood up and strode over to where everyone else was standing. As far as the inn's patrons were concerned, the current tableau had turned into a better piece of live theatre than an actual play.

“Ryoka? Where did *you* come from? I've been looking for you all over!”

Ryoka pointed at an empty chair and a table that had somehow remained empty despite the full room.

“I asked Pisces to put his [Invisibility] spell over me. I've been hanging around here all day.”

Ryoka rubbed at her backside.

“It was a pain in the ass, and I kept having to deal with assholes trying to sit on me, but I saw what I needed to. Lyonette's not the problem, Erin. Those two are.”

She jerked a thumb at Safry and Maran. The two [Barmaids] looked suddenly apprehensive.

“We didn't—”

Ryoka rode right over them. She seemed to be enjoying the moment, in the way only the detective unveiling the mystery at the end of a case, or a judge handing down a sentence could be.

“I watched everything, Erin. Safry and Maran brought in humans so they wouldn't have to serve Drakes and Gnolls as often, they can't tell non-Humans apart, neither of them will go get water, and they take breaks when things are busy. Oh, and they've been grade-A assholes towards Lyonette all day.”

Lyonette's jaw dropped. She hadn't expected this! But it was a relief to hear Ryoka say all of that. More than a relief.

Erin stared at Ryoka. Her eyes slid sideways to Safry and Maran, who were both looking uneasy. Erin thought, and then looked at Ryoka.

“Okay, they're in the wrong. But—”

“Safry pushed Mrsha.”

It was just a little detail, slipped in. Erin was still formulating her next word when it hit her ears and reached her brain. She stopped.

“What?”

“I didn’t—”

Safry backed up as Ryoka turned to her. Ryoka was grinning, but it wasn’t really a grin, more like a rictus of bad feeling.

“Right, it was just a little push. And you were angry. Well, I’m just a little angry. So how about that?”

Ryoka cracked her knuckles, and Safry backed up fast. The Runner eyed her and Maran and nodded to the door.

“If you leave now, I won’t get a chance to break something. Go ahead and stay, I dare you. We’re in Liscor, and I bet Zel wouldn’t bat an eye if I broke your nose for bullying Mrsha.”

“I—”

“Okay! Stop!”

Erin grabbed Ryoka’s shirt and pulled the girl back. Ryoka nearly fell backwards as Erin dragged her away. Erin got between Ryoka and looked at Safry and Maran.

“No one’s beating up anyone. But I’ve heard enough. Safry, Maran, I don’t like to say it, but I believe Ryoka and Lyonette. So you’re both fired. Get out of my inn.”

The two [Barmaids] looked horrified. Lyonette suspected neither had been serious when quitting before, and now they protested loudly.

“You can’t just fire us!”

“I did. Just now.”

Erin crossed her arms, looking uneasy, but also deeply upset. Safry glared at her, turning her ire over the entire situation into unrighteous fury.

“You can’t take away our jobs!”

“You just quit.”

“What are we supposed to do without jobs? Agnes won’t have us back! You owe us pay if you’re going to fire us. The Guild says—”

“I’m not paying you for today. Lyonette says you were miserable, and you pushed Mrsha so just—just go away! I paid you yesterday, so be happy you got that!”

Erin was clearly unhappy, but she stood her ground as the two protested. Ryoka kept trying to edge around her, and Erin was busy pushing her back. Maybe that was why Safry and Maran took a stand.

“We refuse to leave! This isn’t fair! You promised us paying jobs, and now you’re taking them from us! You told us we’d be working in an inn, not hauling water and avoiding monsters, or dealing with [Necromancers], or Ants—”

None of it was true. Some of it was true. It didn’t matter. Because while Ryoka had lost her temper, Lyonette had blown her lid, and Safry and Maran had been furious, it was when Erin got angry that things got scary.

Mrsha was tangled around Erin, Ryoka was fighting to get towards one of the [Barmaids]. They were shrieking at her, and Lyonette saw the world start to shimmer around Erin.

Something changed. The air became hot, and turmoil leaked into the room, grabbing at the hearts of those within. The floor shook as the inn rumbled, and the oppressive menace seeped upwards, grabbing, clutching—

“Leave.”

Erin Solstice was a thing that stood in the dark hallways of fury, watching, waiting, arms folded. Mrsha was a beast of claws and teeth that reached out to engulf and consume.

It was an illusion, but it still frightened Lyonette. And she wasn’t the target. The [Inn’s Aura] Skill sent Safry and Maran running screaming towards the door. They vanished into Octavia’s shop with a *crash* of broken glass and the [Alchemist] shouting and the air of menace faded.

And then it was over. The room cleared, and Erin turned around, looking embarrassed. She found half of her patronage on the floor, the other half frozen with hands on swords. Her cheeks went red, and then she looked at Lyon.

“Why did all that happen, Lyon? I thought you said things were good.”

Lyon had no reply. Now that the two were gone, shame and regret was the menu of the day. She choked on a reply.

“I—”

“It wasn’t her fault, Miss Erin.”

Drassi peeked out from under a table and crawled out. She looked at Lyon.

“Lyon was doing her job, but the other two were...well, they thought they could do less. They just didn’t work as hard as she did, and it was obvious they weren’t at home with our kind.”

“Or ours. One Gnoll is fine, but six is too many, no?”

Ishkr came over, hair slowly settling back down all over his body. Mrsha still looked poofed up to twice her size. Erin sighed, looking helplessly at the floor.

“But they were so *nice*. I worked with Maran and Safry and I never had a problem once!”

“I guess they were a bit like Agnes. Good, but not great. Nice, but not adaptable. Flawed.”

Ryoka shrugged when Erin glared at her. Erin sighed and muttered as she kicked at the ground.

“Why are things so hard? When Toren was here I *never* had to worry about him working. Now I hire friends and it turns out they were bad all along.”

When Toren was here. Lyon heard a ringing sound. She didn’t realize she was striding up to Erin before she was shouting in her face.

“Toren? He was horrible!”

“Wha?”

Erin blinked, caught off-guard by the sudden anger. The crowd ducked back down as the shouting entered overtime.

“Toren was a nightmare! He was the worst!”

“He wasn’t that bad—he was good before he abandoned me and went crazy.”

“No!”

Lyonette screamed the word in Erin’s face, shouting for the first time in...it was all the pent up emotions, all the things she’d wanted to say spilling out at the wrong time in the wrong place.

“He wasn’t *ever* good! He was always a monster! He’d push me into Shield Spider nests, make me run for miles without rest, hit me, abandon me in the middle of nowhere for hours...he was *your skeleton*, but you never controlled him! At all!”

Erin was staring at Lyonette, and slowly the girl realized she was screaming at her employer. She went white, but kept speaking. The words had to be said.

“You never noticed. You never believed me. That was my fault. But you don’t listen to me, or trust me. Even now.”

She looked into Erin’s eyes. The girl stared back shocked, hurt, and guilty. It was everything Lyonette had wanted to say. Everything. Now it was over. Lyonette turned, and ran out of the inn.

Pawn walked through the corridors of his Hive in a daze. He felt confused, despairing, lost.

He’d made a huge mistake. The biggest. No one was better off now that he and his Soldiers weren’t on the front lines. The Antinium were still dying. His people were still dying.

The only difference was that Pawn was safe from it all. Safe, to play with faith and lead his Soldiers around as if nothing was happening.

Pawn stormed into the empty barracks where he slept. He hurled the thurible into his cubicle and hit the Antinium sleeping there. A Worker jerked awake. He was sleeping in Pawn’s spot.

Of course. A second shift. Pawn hurried over.

“I am so sorry. Accept my deepest apologies, please—”

The Worker got up and bent to help Pawn pick up the thurible which was still somehow intact. He bowed to Pawn as Pawn tried to apologize and said two words.

“Individual Pawn.”

They were words that crushed Pawn. The Worker was acknowledging his status. He, Pawn, was an Individual, someone of unique value to the Hive. A Worker’s life was dust compared to that. Pawn could have hurled the thurible into the Worker’s face, told him to leave the cubicle so Pawn could sleep, and the Worker would have done just that.

Because he didn’t matter. He might be sent to combat duty right after this, but Pawn was safe. Because he was special. Because Erin had talked to Klbkch. So his Soldiers would be safe. But the other Soldiers without paint would die.

Nothing was better. Pawn stumbled away, clutching the thurible.

He was useless. Worse than useless.

He was a coward.

Ryoka found Lyonette sitting on a patch of cleared grass, about five minutes away from the inn. The Runner noticed that despite Lyonette being hunched over in a ball of misery in the snow, she’d still put two of the dried seed cores in the snow by her side.

She also looked up when she saw Ryoka approach, and then quickly looked away. It was all sensible, even in her grief. That was what Lyonette was, in a way. More sensible, more adult.

But still young.

And now she had no job. Lyonette didn’t raise her head when the crunching stopped and she sensed Ryoka standing next to her. She waited

for the Runner to speak, but when Ryoka didn't, Lyonette spoke up so the silence wouldn't consume her.

"How did you know?"

"Mrsha and Ishkr showed me the way you'd gone. Gnoll noses are handy."

Lyonette looked up. Her eyes were blurry and her nose was running horribly, so it was hard to see.

"Is Mrsha—"

"She's back at the inn. Moore's levitating her so she can't run off."

Slowly, Ryoka sat down next to Lyonette. She patted herself down for tissues, cursing over leaving her belt pouch in the inn. Lyonette just wiped her face on her sleeve, which was disgusting, but effective.

"I'm gone, aren't I? Erin's going to fire me."

"No she's not. She'd never do that."

"Really?"

"If she did, I'd have to kick her ass, or try, and Mrsha would bite her all over. You were right to shout at her back there. Okay, maybe you screamed a bit, but I think you deserved the chance."

"I didn't mean all of it. It's just—"

Lyonette wiped at her eyes. Her tears were hot, but they froze so quickly in the cold. Ryoka silently pulled off her coat. She had a second one on, and Lyonette had run out in the cold. She winced when Lyonette buried her face in the soft fabric rather than put it on.

"Sounds like you really had it rough with Toren. I'm sorry. I didn't know either, and I was there for part of it."

"I thought—I thought he'd kill me if I told, sometimes. Other times I didn't care, but no one listened. Because I always complained. When he was gone...at first I was the happiest I could ever be, until I realized Erin was gone too. And then you left..."

Guilt passed over Ryoka's face like a shadow.

"Yeah."

“But.”

Lyonette raised her face wretchedly. Her tears were drying up.

“I think I was happiest when Erin was gone. Really. I was. It sounds crazy, but after I started working—when I had to do everything myself, I started being happy. Because I *was* doing it all! I was actually keeping the inn running, and feeding Mrsha, and getting guests—I did it. All by myself.”

“Huh.”

Ryoka sat with Lyon in the snow as the other girl shivered and cried a bit.

“I did it. I got honey, I helped Pawn. I did it all. Then Erin came back and she did so much I couldn’t dream of! She had a magic door, magic food, she knows all these recipes, and she can *cook*...”

“But she wasn’t the one who got all the Gold-rank adventurers and Zel Shivertail to stay at your inn, right? She didn’t keep Mrsha happy. Neither did I.”

“I know it’s silly, but I just thought she’d trust me after that!”

Lyonette sobbed into her coat. Ryoka paused.

“She should have. But Erin...I don’t think it was about trust. She just did what she thought was best and, well, it backfired for once. Only it looks like you had to deal with it.”

“It’s not her fault!”

“It really is.”

Ryoka sat next to Lyonette as the girl gulped down air.

“I just don’t know why I feel so unhappy sometimes!”

She confessed to Ryoka, shivering as the wind blew.

“I want to do more, make more decisions even though it’s Erin’s inn. But I know it’s hers. I was just managing it. I know that, but I still want...to be an [Innkeeper] too. Or be something else. I know it’s bad.”

“It’s not bad.”

Ryoka's voice was soft as she poked at some ice-crusting snow. She glanced at Lyonette. The girl was wiping at her face again.

"I don't know why I feel this way. I should be happy. Mrsha's here, I have a good life, I get *paid*, no one's after me or angry with me..."

"Yeah, well, I think it's because you're a terrible [Barmaid]."

Ryoka sensed the other girl looking up. She coughed delicately.

"What I mean by that is that you're not meant to be serving people drinks. You're good at your job—too good, in fact. A decent [Barmaid] is someone like Safry, who works hard but not too hard. She's a lazy, prejudiced, arrogant bitch at times too, but she does her job and that's it. If she were a great barmaid, she wouldn't have all those qualities. But you—you're different."

She looked over at Lyonette and saw the girl staring at her, red-eyed, shivering. It wasn't a glamorous face, but the owner of it had the courage to walk into a nest full of bees big enough to put a stinger right through her skull. Looks were deceiving.

"Erin's perfect as an [Innkeeper] because it seems like she can make her inn do whatever she wants. But you have too many ideas to just serve drinks for her. You're too capable. You should be an [Innkeeper] yourself, at the very least. But then, you're not meant for that either, are you? You are a [Princess]."

An indrawn breath. Ryoka nodded.

"Thought so. Let's keep that a secret between us, huh?"

"How did—"

"It's not exactly hard to guess, at least, back when you were screaming about how important you were. Look, it doesn't matter to me, although I'd keep it a secret. But I think it means you can do more than just serve drinks, that's all. You were managing those other two pretty well when Safry and Maran weren't getting in the way."

She nodded back in the direction of the inn. Lyonette didn't know what to say.

“But I’m a failure. I never reached more than Level 5 in my [Princess] class.”

“Really? Level 5? That’s interesting. Maybe the you back then didn’t have a chance or you were...spoiled rotten and bratty. But now, I think if you put your mind to it, things might change.”

Ryoka grinned. Lyonette stared at her, parts of her chest lighting up from within.

“You think so?”

“It’s worth a shot. Being a [Princess] isn’t just about where you are or what you’re wearing. It’s what you do. And I think the most princess-like thing you did was stand up for Mrsha back then. Which reminds me, you know magic, don’t you?”

“Yes. I was tutored a bit, but I never learned much. Just a few spells like [Light]. Hardly anything.”

“[Light]’s the most basic and useful thing in the world. Don’t knock it. For instance, light can do this.”

Ryoka raised a finger, and in the desolate landscape, light flashed. Lyonette cried out and shielded her eyes. When she could see, Ryoka looked abashed.

“Sorry. But now you’ve seen it, you can copy it. I call it [Flashbang]. Well, that’s only half of it. You also make a sound like this—”

This time Lyonette clapped a hand to her ears, but the *bang* was still deafening. Ryoka nodded at her as she took trembling hands away from her ears.

“You could probably learn that in a bit.”

“But how—I never knew a spell like that existed!”

“There’s probably some version of it out in the world. Pisces might know it. But I invented that myself. It’s just a bit of protection magic. If you’re gifted enough, you should try learning that and a few more spells. Typhenous or Ceria might teach you. And pick up a sword while you’re at it.”

“You think I should do all that?”

Learn to use a sword. Learn to use magic. More classes. The idea burned in Lyonette like a flame built of tinder, burning hot but quick to be extinguished. But Ryoka nodded as if that were natural.

“A princess should know how to do all kinds of things. I know it’s not good to have too many classes, but...well, it’s just a hunch. If a princess really knows her people, then she should know what they do, at least a bit.”

She smiled at Lyon, and the girl smiled back.

“No one in my family would ever think that way.”

“Yeah? What level are they?”

Lyonette was speechless. Ryoka sighed, and stood up.

“That was probably rude of me. Sorry. But you look like you’re feeling better.”

That was true. Lyonette felt better. She was still unhappy, but that was because all that had just passed, not because of the future. Ryoka smiled at her, awkwardly. She was a bit like Ishkr. If she worked at the inn, Ryoka would probably let her gather Ashfire Bee honey and go shopping by herself.

“I’ve got to go. I’m taking Mrsha to visit Garia’s family tonight and staying over for a day or two. Don’t worry; I think it’ll be fine when you return. Erin’s falling over herself trying to find ways to apologize, and those other two seem to think you’re worth listening to.”

“I’ll go back and apologize—”

Lyon stood up, but Ryoka held up a hand.

“If I were you, I’d keep Erin sweating just a bit longer. She needs to think more about other people sometimes.”

She winked as Lyonette stared up at her and jogged off. Lyonette watched her go, and wondered if Ryoka had been like her once. Or maybe she just understood what Lyon was going through.

It was a [Barmaid] that left the inn, sobbing, guilty. But it was a [Princess] that trudged back. A princess wearing a coat with snot and tears all over it, and a [Princess] whose eyes were red and whose nose still ran, but a [Princess] nevertheless. She couldn’t forget that.

She was a [Princess].

With levels in the [Barmaid] class.

Pawn waited until his shift and slept. He didn't know what he'd done in the meantime. He just...existed until the point where he could consign himself to oblivion for a little while. Then he woke.

He felt like a zombie, lifeless, shambling along. The exhilaration that had filled him yesterday was gone.

How could he have been so blind? His people died no matter what he did. How could he be so happy over a useless Skill, two level ups?

[Mass Prayer]. What good was that? What good was praying, together or alone? It did nothing. Pawn turned, and punched the dirt wall of his sleeping area.

"Useless."

He would have slept there, letting other Workers file in and out if someone hadn't approached his hiding place. Pawn looked up when the light filled the dark room.

"Pawn. I have been looking for you."

Xrn, the Small Queen, bent over Pawn as he clutched the thurible to his chest. He stared up at her, radiant, her eyes shining with magic.

"Go away."

"I cannot do that, Pawn. I am told you have not visited your Soldiers in days. They are waiting for you. They are restless. They need you to lead them."

"I deserve to lead no one. All I did was get them killed. Protecting *me*."

"Fighting. They fought for the Hive."

"At my command. They did it for me. It was my fault."

A pause. Xrn bent down next to Pawn, scrutinizing him curiously.

“But they are Soldiers. They are made to fight. What else would they do?”

“Live.”

Pawn whispered the word.

“I don’t want them to die. I want them to live.”

“Some may live if you command them. If not, what do you think will happen? Refuse, and they will be put on the front lines. Forced to fight. Without you.”

The knowledge was bitter, undeniable. Pawn didn’t respond. He heard Xrn sigh.

“What if one of the other Individuals led them? Your friend Belgrade, or Anand.”

“They’re [Tacticians]. They can do it. They know how to lead.”

“Pawn.”

“Go away. I am sulking.”

“I will not go. I am going to convince you to get up, Pawn. You see, I am no [Leader] either, Pawn. I am a [Thaumaturge], a class derived from [Mage]. I did not choose to lead either.”

Pawn shook his head, denying Xrn to her face.

“That is a false argument. You were created for the role. You are one of the Centenium, a Prognugator. You are a leader. I am not like you. I cannot do what you do. I cannot...lead an army. I cannot lead a single Worker.”

“But you are a [Tactician] as well, are you not? Like Belgrade and Anand. If they lead, why will you not?”

“Because a [Tactician] orders Soldiers to fight and die! I cannot do that. I can only stand and let the Soldiers fight themselves. But I cannot—I am not like Belgrade or Anand. I do not see the link between the chess board and reality! I have no talent for it, do you understand?”

Pawn cried out. He uncurled from his ball and stood up, shaking.

“What kind of a [General] sits and hides behind his Soldiers and does nothing? What kind of leader would do that?”

Xrn stared at him. Pawn was breathing heavily, his mandibles closing and parting.

“I cannot fight. If I did—my Soldiers would die protecting me. I have no talent for it. I cannot lead. I cannot order them to battle. I have no talent for that either. I can only ask them to die for me. I can do nothing else. What can I give them?”

Something in Pawn whispered. *Faith. Hope. Identity.* He forced the feeling down. It wasn't enough. It was enough to live for, but not enough to ask them to die for. Xrn shook her head. She did not know either. The part of Pawn that had hoped she would curled up in despair again.

“I have no answer. But you cannot hide from your duty forever.”

“Why? What is my duty? Is it to my Queen? My Hive?”

Xrn nodded.

“Partly. But you have a greater duty still, Pawn of the Free Antinium. The duty all Antinium share.”

“What is that?”

“The duty of the Antinium, Pawn, is to survive. We go to war, we struggle, and we die, all for the same purpose. That some may live. That one may live. All this time, across thousands of miles and an ocean, we have come for one reason. To survive.”

It was the same phrase, the same idea, wrapped up differently. Pawn turned away, bitter.

“At what cost?”

“Anything less than the whole of our species is acceptable.”

“Not to me. Go away.”

He turned back to his cubicle. He felt Xrn's eyes watching him. Eventually she left. And once again, Pawn went to find Erin.

He didn't find her. Erin was in the city, screaming at and being screamed at by a Miss Agnes and other people named Safry and Maran, according to the Drake who greeted him at the door. He sat miserably in the inn, not touching his food until Zel found him.

"You look like chewed up Creler bait. Pawn, right?"

He didn't know why, but the Drake [General] sat with him, waiting for Pawn to speak. Pawn wanted to and feared to at the same time. He looked sideways at Zel.

"I thought you did not like Antinium."

The Drake coughed a few times.

"True. But Erin and Lyonette happened to mention you led some soldiers into battle for the first time a few days ago. I've been there. I thought I might...listen. That's all."

Pawn stared at him, at Zel Shivertail, a [General], a Drake hero. The words tumbled out too fast for him to stop.

"I let them die. They were defending me and—"

"Stop."

Zel made Pawn stop and repeat the story from the start. The Drake shook his head.

"Sounds like every story I've heard. You went in, you fought. And some of your soldiers died. There's not a commander on the continent that hasn't felt like you have."

"Really?"

Pawn sat up a bit. Zel nodded seriously.

"The key is knowing that they fought for a reason. If it was a bad reason, well, that's a problem. But they fought because they believed in you, Pawn. Honor that, and keep leading them, or what was the point?"

Pawn sagged.

"That's not the problem. It is that *I* cannot lead them."

"Why not?"

“I keep telling everyone, I am no leader. I cannot order them in battle. But if I do not—”

“Who will?”

Zel was nodding. The Drake seemed to understand Pawn’s dilemma more than most.

“And if you don’t, who will? If you don’t, folks still die. Blood’s on your claws either way.”

“Exactly.”

Pawn shivered.

“Is there a good answer for this, Zel Shivertail?”

Zel paused, and the Antinium knew the answer already. Then the Drake spoke.

“You know, hearing what you’re going through reminds me of what I used to hear from Sserys all the time.”

“Who is that?”

“Oh, no one special. You wouldn’t remember. Anyways...”

The Drake trailed off and then shook his head briskly. He looked at Pawn.

“He told me to keep looking around, at my officers, at my soldiers. In each battle, in war, in peace, look for someone who can inspire others. Someone with talent, courage, a spark. And then to nurture that spark until that individual can surpass me. Only then would I step aside.”

“If no one else can command, you must.”

It was a very Drake-like thing to think. Pawn understood. Zel nodded, swishing his tail slowly across the floor.

“How about it? Do you see anyone in your command who could lead better than you? Or are you the only one who can do what’s right?”

He looked at Pawn, gingerly resting his claws on the Antinium’s shoulder. Pawn realized what he was supposed to say, that there was no one else. This was his duty. But that would be a lie.

“Every single Soldier under my command knows war better than I, General Shivertail. Any of them could lead. I cannot.”

It wasn't the right answer. But it was in Pawn's heart. Zel sighed and turned away.

“I understand. But your Soldiers have no command, Pawn. I've fought them long enough to see that. Some might gain a high [Soldier] class, and they're a terror to fight on the battlefield. But in the end, a [Soldier] is just a soldier. He cannot lead. You can.”

He left Pawn then, because he'd said all he could. Pawn sat there, waiting for nothing, waiting for Erin, when someone spoke his name.

“Pawn?”

It was Lyonette. She sat with him as a Gnoll covered for her. Pawn stared at Lyonette.

“Hello.”

“You look terrible. What's wrong? Are you...it's the Soldiers, right?”

She knew. Pawn didn't have to explain. He felt relieved. But some part of him kept talking, kept explaining anyways.

“Everyone tells me I should lead, should bring my Soldiers back into battle. But *I* cannot be a leader. I tell everyone this. There is no [General] who is useless. Belgrade, Anand, Klbkch...they can all fight, and tell Soldiers how to do battle. Even Bird could inflict damage if he led a unit. But I...I am not a warrior. How can I lead Soldiers who will fight for me?”

He expected Lyonette to come up with some sage advice like the others. But she just shrugged.

“I don't know. If you think you can't lead them, then you can't. But they still trust you, right?”

Pawn nodded. His painted Soldiers would follow him to the ends of the earth. They would fight any foe for him; sacrifice their lives if they had to. He was not worthy of that.

“In that case, maybe you're not like a [General], then. Maybe you're like me.”

Pawn paused. He looked over.

“Like you? I am not Human. I am not female. I am not a [Barmaid].”

“But you are bad at fighting. So am I. And I...am a [Princess].”

He stared. Lyonette smiled as she looked around conspiratorially.

“What you’re facing sounds like what I’d do in war. [Princesses] and [Queens] don’t lead armies. Most of them don’t, anyways. Back home...no one would dream of it. I hear it’s different in Chandrar and Rhir, but Terandrian nobility don’t let women fight as often as the boys.”

“Then what do you do if a battle occurs?”

“Nothing. We just sit behind our warriors. But because we’re there, it matters. You see?”

“Not at all. Please explain.”

Lyonette sat with Pawn at the table and drank from his mug, since he wasn’t thirsty. She slowly began to speak.

“There was a story my mother used to tell me, of a [Queen] who was ambushed while her nation was at war. Her protectors fought while she sat on a chair in the middle of the battlefield, not moving, not trying to run.”

“But if she had run—”

“Her warriors would have to protect her, and they might get hurt trying to shield her. She might do more damage running, get it? But since she stayed still, they could fight knowing she was protected by them. In my mother’s story, the battle raged on and the Queen’s soldiers were falling back, but then she said one word. ‘Fight.’”

“And they did?”

Lyonette smiled.

“One word from her inspired her soldiers to drive the enemy back. They didn’t want her to take up arms herself. They knew their Queen couldn’t fight. But because she believed in them and showed not a trace of fear on her face, they fought like heroes to protect her. Because she was worth dying for.”

“But what if she was not? What if she was worthless?”

“It didn’t matter. Because they believed. And whose belief mattered most? Hers? Or theirs?”

Pawn thought of his Soldiers. He stirred. Something in him stirred.

“If they fought, they would die.”

“Some. But it’s their choice, isn’t it? The [Queen]’s soldiers could have run. But they held their ground.”

“And if they all die?”

Lyonette’s face twisted. She looked sad.

“I guess they died fighting for what they believed in. That’s something. I don’t know.”

Belief. Pawn’s head lowered. He looked down at something clutched in his hands. It was called a thurible.

Religion. A class. Leading Soldiers. Thurible. All the pieces came together. Pawn stood up.

“I know what I must do.”

“Lead?”

“Something close to it.”

The pieces all fit. Pawn was not worthy of being a leader. But he was good at one thing. One thing. And if...

He started for the door, and stopped to look at Lyonette.

“Thank you. Your advice helped me greatly.”

“Don’t go just yet.”

To his surprise, Lyonette stopped him. She studied him critically.

“Before you go, you need to learn how to act. If you’re going to lead. Even if it’s just walking with your Soldiers.”

“Why? What is wrong?”

“You walk like a peas...like someone afraid of the world. But if you’re leading others, you must do it bravely, gracefully. Like this.”

Lyonette's head rose. She stared down at Pawn, and suddenly she looked a bit taller, a bit straighter. He stared.

"How are you doing that?"

She smiled and showed him.

"Head straight, chin up. Look ahead, not down. Straighten your spine... or whatever it is you have. Don't hunch up. Stand like this."

When Pawn walked towards the door this time, he walked straighter than he had in his life. The world seemed a bit lower down, and a bit brighter for some reason. Lyonette walked with him.

"You'll be okay? You'll be safe?"

"I hope so. But I do not know. I only know...yes, I know what I must do."

"And what's that?"

Lyonette held the door open for him. Pawn clutched the thurible, a packet of cinnamon, and a few unused coals to his chest. He nodded at Lyonette.

"I will pray."

They were waiting for him when he returned. They had been there, waiting. He had left them, but they had not left. They had faith he would return.

Would that he had the same. Pawn stood before his Soldiers and raised his voice. He looked among them, each one different, and each one unique. Precious.

Irreplaceable.

"We will go back into battle."

They did not stir. This was not a surprise to them. They accepted death like life. But Pawn had to explain.

“I do not wish for any of you to die. I would rather die than let that happen.”

They did stir then. The Soldiers looked at Pawn. He bowed his head.

“You are not just Soldiers to me. You are my people. You should not die. But if you do not fight, others of our kind will die. Either way, we die. We as the Antinium die.”

The Soldiers looked at each other. Pawn stared down at them.

“To fight is to die, and that is unbearable. But to do nothing is worse still. If we can fight to protect our people, so that others may live, it is right.”

They did not nod. But each one of them agreed in his own way. Pawn nodded.

“But I cannot command. I am no [General], no [Tactician], and no [Mage]. I cannot do anything for you.”

Silence. Pawn stared at the Soldiers, who looked back. Confused. If he would not lead, who would? The Antinium needed a leader. When Pawn spoke next, it was a whisper.

“You. Step forwards.”

He pointed at one of the Antinium, the one with yellow splatters of paint. The Soldier stepped forwards slowly. He was a Soldier like the others. But he had been one of the first Pawn had led above. He had survived. And a Drake grandmother recognized him. These were all small reasons. But enough.

“I am not worthy of a command. I do not know war. But you do. You have fought longer than I have. You know battle. You know each other. So come. Step forwards.”

The Soldier approached. Pawn walked towards him, and put a hand on the Soldier’s chest. The Soldier stared down at him. Pawn’s voice was trembling.

“As Individual Pawn, given command of this unit of Soldiers, I, with the authority of my Hive, promote you. You are no longer a [Soldier]. You are a [Sergeant].”

The world stopped. The soldier with yellow splatters froze. The other soldiers stared at him. Pawn lowered his hand.

“It is heavy. It is difficult. But you are fit for command. You can lead the others. You will be their leader.”

Yellow Splatters stared down at Pawn. The Soldier was filled with emotions he couldn't name, feelings that words wouldn't describe. He turned, and suddenly every Soldier in the room was staring at him.

No. Not every Soldier.

His Soldiers.

The knowledge drove Yellow Splatters to his knees. But someone was by his side.

“You will not be alone. We will go to the front within the hour. I have requested it.”

We. The word made every Soldier look at Pawn. He was holding something in his hands. The Worker stared around at the other Soldiers as he lit a flame.

“I cannot be your leader. I cannot. But I could never abandon you. I will walk with you in battle. I will be by your side. I will do the only thing I can do.”

The flame caught. The ember glowed as Pawn held it in a hand. He dropped it into the thurible, and the incense began to burn. It was not frankincense or myrrh. It was cinnamon sticks, ground finely. It was sweet, and the smoke drifted across the Soldiers as Pawn walked past them.

“Come.”

Xrn found Klbkch, tired, overseeing a group of Workers as they struggled to repair a wall. Workers and Soldiers filled the Hive, tirelessly moving from place to place.

“Klbkch. I am told Pawn went to see you.”

“Yes, he did. It was curious.”

Klbgch answered shortly, exhausted and tired as he was from fighting. He noticed Xrn staring at him in concern and straightened a bit.

“What was so odd about it?”

“Many things. Pawn requested to be assigned to combat duty with his entire unit of Soldiers.”

Xrn stared at Klbgch. Electric flashes of yellow alarm shot through the green nebula of surprise filling her eyes.

“*All* of them?”

“That is what I said.”

Klbgch turned to look at Xrn. Surprise was written across the Small Queen’s face, a rare sight. Her voice trembled a bit as she asked the next question.

“When is he to go into battle?”

Klbgch smiled.

“Right now.”

The Hive. Workers and Soldiers marched in an unending flow down one of the tunnels. One of many in the Hive. Despite the Antinium’s reputation for silence, the hallways were still filled with sound. The echoes of footfalls, the shifting of bodies—these were all sounds that occupied the air.

There were no voices, though. The sounds of footfalls, of bodies moving and the air rustling was just noise. There was a kind of silence even when Soldiers were rushing down the tunnels. The silence of those without words.

And then the silence was broken. A single sound suddenly pierced the repetitive noises, a distinctive aberration.

Click.

The sound echoed down the corridor, causing the lines of Soldiers and Workers to slow. It was a sound none of them had heard, not like this.

Click.

It was too loud, and it echoed. It was not the click of a single mandible, but countless ones. It was a strange sound, and all the Workers and Soldiers looked around for the source.

Click.

There it was again. Now all heads turned to look down the corridor. The Antinium stopped. They looked. And then they stared.

Someone was walking down the hallway. It was a small shape, like the others. And not.

A Worker walked slowly down the lines of Antinium, the others parting before him. He held something in his hands. A censer, bound by string. A thurible, leaking smoke that smelled like nothing the other Antinium had ever experienced.

The incense drifted as the Antinium slowly shook the thurible. He walked forwards, and smoke drifted past him like mist.

And others followed. Soldiers, the painted few walked, stepping, stopping, following in the Worker's wake. And then the other Antinium heard it.

Click.

Each time they stepped, the Soldiers' mandibles clicked together, making that distinctive sound. They made that sound. The Soldiers, who had no voice. Yet the sound was an echo, a thunder.

A word for the voiceless.

And then those around the Worker heard something else. A resonance. A feeling in the air. Quiet. It came from the Worker.

He was...*humming*. The other Antinium had never heard a sound like it. Pawn's voice was low, deep, and resonant. It should not have filled the huge tunnel, but it did.

Click.

Each Soldier's mandible snapped together at the same time. The sound was louder than any Rock Crab could ever make, a *snap* that broke the air and echoed for miles in the Hive.

Click.

Another step.

Click.

The Antinium parted, and Pawn and the painted Soldiers followed him. Workers and Soldiers alike paused in their duty, going to war, carrying supplies, going to rest. Each one saw something, heard something they had never experienced in that moment.

Each one.

"I do not understand."

Tersk clutched at his bare chest. His hands met only chitin, and he stared as Belgrade used his two good arms to support himself against a wall. Tersk's voice was hoarse, strained.

"I cannot express this word. This feeling. What is it? I see Pawn. But it is not just him. There is something..."

His voice trailed away. Belgrade stared at Pawn as the Worker walked the halls of his Hive. To battle. His head was lowered, and the Worker prayed. Behind him, the Soldiers did the same. Belgrade had a word for it, and he spoke it for Tersk to hear.

"Faith."

They watched as the Antinium passed. They alone saw and understood the rest. Xrn clutched at Klbkch's arm, so tightly he thought his body might break.

"Oh Klbkch. Do you see him? He is just like we were once."

"He is not. It is not...not the same."

It was pride that made Klbkch say that. But he couldn't take his eyes off of Pawn. The *click* of the Soldiers' mandibles echoed in his soul. He saw another group in their shadow. Antinium of the past, long gone.

Heroes.

Xrn shook her head, her eyes not leaving Pawn.

"No. It is exactly the same. They have not forgotten, Klbkch. These fragments, these children, they have the same spirit. The same courage."

She whispered.

"They are Antinium."

He had no name. He was a Soldier. He had no identity. If there was any way to distinguish him now, it would be Soldier with a Damaged Antennae. Both of his had been damaged in a skirmish with cave Goblins.

Now Soldier with a Damaged Antennae fought desperately, punching with his fists at a huge suit of enchanted armor. Soldier with a Damaged Antennae had no fear, but he realized he would die. The suit of armor had lost his axe, buried in two of Soldier with a Damaged Antennae's friends, but he was too tough.

Too strong. The armor struck Soldier with a Damaged Antennae with a kick that broke something in the Antinium's chest. The Soldier stumbled, fell. He put one of his hands to his chest as he grabbed the armor with his other three hands and tried to hold him back.

Green blood. A lot of it. This was it. Soldier with a Damaged Antennae tried to muster the strength to fight, but his arms gave in despite themselves. The armor threw him to the ground and raised a foot. Soldier with a Damaged Antennae stared up, waiting for death.

Then there was color.

Someone *charged* into the suit of armor, throwing it backwards. The fallen Soldier stared, as a Soldier with yellow splatters of color on his

carapace tackled the enchanted armor, throwing it backwards. A huge fist rose, and then smashed into the enchanted armor's chest plate.

Aid had come. Soldier with a Damaged Antennae struggled to rise. The other Soldier could not do it alone. But he was so weak! Soldier with a Damaged Antennae stumbled up.

And then he saw it. A fallen suit of armor, chest plate caved in. The Soldier with yellow splatters of paint rose, uninjured, and turned. He raised an arm and the ground shook. Soldiers painted in every color thundered past him.

Soldier with a Damaged Antennae had no words for it. These Soldiers were like him, but not. They were painted, with colors. That was all, but they seemed larger. Stronger. More alive.

The Soldier with yellow splatters led the charge. They charged towards a Crypt Worm, fearless. And the Soldier with a Damaged Antennae stared after them. There was a word for them, a word that set them apart from him. The Soldier searched for it, and thought of the word as he stared at the yellow splattered Soldier's back.

A hero.

He staggered. Blood dripped onto his hand. Soldier with a Damaged Antennae began to fall again. But someone caught him.

A Worker. Soldier with a Damaged Antennae stared at him. The Worker had something that smoked and gave off a pleasant smell in his hand. He caught Soldier with a Damaged Antennae and spoke to him.

"You will not die. Have faith."

He was small, but he walked among the monsters without fear. The Worker carried Soldier with a Damaged Antennae back, as the painted Soldiers fought around him. He prayed, and told the injured Soldier he would live.

And the Soldier believed. That day he lived. And when he looked up, chest clumsily bandaged, he saw the painted Soldiers marching back. And the Worker was leading them. He might have said otherwise, but they followed him.

Because they had faith.

That night, Pawn sat outside of the Wandering Inn, in the snow. Not much snow; it had been mostly cleared away. But there was no room inside the inn, not for more than a hundred Soldiers.

He scraped the bottom of his bowl. Today had been bee soup, thick with butter and fat. It was good, and Pawn had eaten his first bowl. He looked around and saw most of the other Soldiers had done the same. But none would speak up, or move. They probably thought that was all.

“Erin made plenty of soup. There’s enough for everyone to have as much as they want, okay?”

The Soldiers looked at him. No one moved, not even Yellow Splatters. Pawn smiled a bit. Ah, well, bravery in battle was one thing. He raised his hand.

“I believe we shall all have seconds, Lyonette.”

“Coming up!”

The young woman smiled and came over with a hot bowl, served fresh from the series of pots Erin had made up. She filled Pawn’s bowl, did the same for all the Soldiers nearby, and then paused in front of a bulkier Antinium.

“A bowl of soup, Prognugator Tersk?”

“I...yes, please.”

Tersk held out his bowl and let Lyonette fill it. Some of the soup got on his chest, but that was fine because as he pointed out to Lyon, he was not wearing his armor.

He had not been wearing his armor for a while. That might have been because his chest was still damaged from battle, but Pawn thought there was another reason.

Now Tersk approached Pawn and sat awkwardly with him and the other Soldiers. He stared around the quiet hilltop, and then spoke.

“I suggest using the remains of these Shield Spiders to construct armor for your Soldiers.”

Straight and to the point. Pawn nodded in approval of the idea.

“Do you know how to make such armor, Prognugator Tersk? I do not, although I would gladly like to learn how.”

Tersk nodded and hesitated.

“The Armored Antinium do not have enough metal to outfit all of our Soldiers. Thus, we use materials like monster hides, or bark to outfit our Workers and some of our Soldiers. That is a secret my Queen would not wish me to speak of, lest the other Hives hear of it.”

“Ah.”

“Yes.”

They sat together. At last, Tersk sighed.

“I believe I will regret leaving this place. But it is necessary. My Hive must know of what the Free Antinium have done.”

“Yes. I also believe imbibing some of Erin’s magical cooking will help with protecting my Soldiers.”

“Indeed. And if I may take the recipe for this... ‘bee soup’ with me, I believe my Queen will rejoice.”

“I think so, Prognugator Tersk.”

Pawn sipped at his soup. It was good. He looked across his ranks of Soldiers. Some were injured, but all had wanted to be here. Some were missing. They now rested on the walls of the barracks.

It hurt. It hurt so much. But they had saved lives. They had fought. This was Pawn’s duty. He bowed his head and Tersk looked at him.

“What are you thinking, Pawn?”

“Nothing, Tersk. I am praying.”

“Oh.”

After a while, the Prognugator spoke.

“Would you teach me how?”

Pawn smiled.

“It is very simple. All you have to do is have faith. And believe.”

“In what?”

The Worker turned and looked across the hilltop. Soldiers raised their heads, looking at him. They all knew the answer.

“Us.”

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Day 59

The two armies met at the foothills leading up towards the mountains of the High Pass. Columns of Drakes and Gnoll [Soldiers] stood at attention as two groups rode to meet each other.

They were not enemies, but even so, Thrissiam Blackwing rode with a heavy escort of his officers and soldiers. Out here in the wilderness, ambushes from monsters and other forces were a very real threat, even for an army. And of course there was the matter of formality. That was just as important as concerns of safety.

As he rode towards the [General] from the other army, Thrissiam made out a few features and placed her at once. The Trisstal Allaince had sent one of their best. Perhaps their second best, which was their best at the moment since Zel Shivertail had taken a leave of absence.

That jarred with Thrissiam's plans greatly. He'd expected to take seniority in the effort to hunt down and destroy the Goblin Lord and his army, but the Gnoll riding towards him on a warhorse stallion far larger than his mare was no low-level [General] he could order around.

Drakes had a social hierarchy. More than that, they had a strict way of dealing with the chain of command, even when dealing with opposing factions. Thrissiam was from one of the Walled Cities. He hailed from Pallass, most northern of the six Walled Cities. It had been chosen to lead the suppression effort against the Goblins. As one of its better [Generals], Thrissiam was naturally an important Drake although he was not quite as important as a council member, Lord or Lady of the Wall, or the most elite echelons of Drake nobility.

However, he was damn close. And coming from a Walled City conferred its own authority. Thrissiam would have felt fairly confident of his superiority to another common [General] of the same rank, but the Gnoll [General] riding towards him outranked him as one of the lead generals of the coalition of smaller Drake city-states, and probably had a few levels on him as well.

So Thrissiam sighed and bowed his head slightly first as the two [Generals] met in the snow. His officers murmured quietly, but Thrissiam wasn't here for a conflict. One [General] had to take charge and if he couldn't state his authority without a struggle, it might as well be her.

Her. Garusa Weatherfur, of the Longstride Clan. She inclined her head towards Thrissiam, giving him the same level of respect. When she spoke, her voice was a clear, deep rumble, which was reassuring. No [General] should ever speak quietly, especially when the roar of battle called for a voice like thunder.

"Hrr. It is good to see you Thrissiam Blackwing. I trust your forces encountered no difficulties on the march here?"

"None, thank you Garusa Weatherfur. We slew four Wyverns on the way, and I hope to recover their corpses on the march back."

"Hm. You seem to think we shall find and dispose of the Goblin Lord quickly, yes?"

Thrissiam directed his mount left, so he and Garusa could talk where their words were removed from the hearing of others. It was bitingly cold as wind blew down from the mountains, and his stupid mare seemed more interested in flirting with Garusa's stallion than staying still. He used his tail to gently slap his horse on the side and she, used to the command, stilled.

Drakes sat on a higher saddle than other races, to allow their tails to run down and around the horse. It took a special breed of horse that was used to having a tail resting on it, but Drakes could actually give commands with their legs and tails when their hands were full. But despite his higher seat, Thrissiam still found himself looking up at Garusa. Her fur was a very light brown, almost blonde, and ruffled as the wind blew it. Apart from her armor, she wore no clothing against the cold. Thrissiam was covered in cloth by comparison.

"I don't see why we shouldn't finish this campaign by the end of winter at the latest, no matter how far the Goblin Lord runs. One [General] is overkill for the strongest Goblin Chieftain. Two should be far more than a match for a Goblin Lord, especially given your abilities."

There. That was a nod to her higher status. Thrissiam had to acknowledge that Garusa was a famous leader in her own right. Gnolls

lived in Drake cities of course—they weren't all tribal wanderers—but it was rare for a Gnoll to achieve high ranking in the Drake-dominated militaries. To be a [General] like her meant she truly was exemplary. Thrissiam had to admit, privately, that no Gnoll would have achieved such honors in a Walled City.

But Garusa surprised Thrissiam by what she said next.

“I do not intend to lead this army, Thrissiam Blackwing. I may be high level, and higher between the two of us, yes, but you are a [Lineholder General], yes? I think your formations would do best against Goblins, if you will leave the attacking to me.”

She was a specialist in brutal assaults, probably one of the reasons why she had been chosen to go up against the disorganized Goblin armies. But to cede command to him? Thrissiam's eyes widened. It was what he wanted, and what was best, he felt. That she was willing to lower her tail increased his respect for her.

“I shall accept with gratitude, Garusa.”

The tension between the two [Generals] eased now that the order of command was established. They were equals, but one now commanded the overall army. Thrissiam would be only too happy to let Garusa lead the attack as well—two generals made for a devastating combination, especially when their natures were opposed, such as in this case. One could use all of his Skills to defend while the other struck out.

They were discussing the compositions of their armies when Garusa said something that made Thrissiam stop his horse dead in its tracks.

“I received a communication from General Shivertail a day ago. He warned me not to underestimate this Goblin Lord. To that end, I have requested several City Runners and more [Scouts] for my army. I hope to keep them in reserve in case things become dire.”

The Drake [General] stared at the Gnoll. What was that? A group to send messages in case of an emergency? That was a last sign of desperation—as if Garusa expected their armies to be overwhelmed! It was also extraordinary because [Mages] could send a [Message] spell just as fast if they weren't busy.

And Zel Shivertail had told her that? The famous Tidebreaker, hero of the Drakes, was certainly known to Thrissiam. He privately idolized Zel Shivertail and envied Garusa the chance to speak with him as a fellow general in the same alliance. But this? He had to shake his head.

“I hardly think your precautions are appropriate, General Weatherfur. We are two [*Generals*] in command of armies worthy of any on the continent!”

“Yes. Hrr. Except that the fabled army of Liscor fought in the Second Antinium War and was defeated by a single Goblin Lord’s army. Not by the King, yes? I would hardly like to compare myself to that force of old, although between us we might be close. I simply remember the past, General Blackwing.”

Thrissiam stared at Garusa and shook his head briskly to dispel the uneasy feeling her words had evoked. He put a bit of fire into his words, although neither she nor he were raw recruits.

“Thinking of defeat is a waste of time and energy. Goblin Lord or not, we are two [*Generals*] and we have over twenty thousand [*Soldiers*] between us. We’ll do this by the book.”

“Which one?”

Garusa grinned toothily as Thrissiam shot an irritated glance at her. Gnoll humor. He grunted as he surveyed the terrain. He really hoped the Goblins hadn’t retreated into the mountains. They’d die up there, and his forces would too trying to flush them out. But the hills were a more likely bet.

“We’ll take a day to combine armies, and then send out scouts. We forge ahead, and find where their war host is hiding. They can’t stay here forever, not without a food source.”

“Hm. Yes. I defer to your experience.”

The Gnoll [*General*] inclined her head, which relieved Thrissiam. She sniffed at the air as she turned her head to stare up at the High Passes.

“I wonder why the Goblin Lord took his forces here?”

“He probably found out we were coming and decided to hide. This one’s not a complete fool, although he’s still doomed in the end.”

Thrissiam grunted. He knew Goblin Lords could employ advanced tactics like scouting their enemy, or battle strategy, although he'd never actually faced one in combat. The Tidebreaker himself had warned Garusa? Did that mean he thought this one might be...? No. Focus.

"We'll establish a camp on one of the larger hills. Somewhere to strike from if we can't locate any signs of the Goblins at once."

Garusa nodded as she and Thrissiam began riding back to their officers. It would be busy, coordinating the joint army, but Drake armies were adaptable and disciplined. Far better than Human armies, which could never work together if their [Lords] were at odds. Even the worst Drake enemies could link tails to take on a common foe.

Thrissiam paused as he stared around the dark landscape. A common foe. He glanced at Garusa and sighed.

"And we'll keep a reserve unit of [Scouts] and Runners if you have them. Spread around the army. Just in case."

She smiled, and Thrissiam gave her his own nod. He could be reasonable too. The joint suppression armies set out to find the Goblin Lord. They were hunting him.

But they didn't realize *he* was also hunting *them*.

Osthia Blackwing did not, in fact, have black wings. Hers were a dark yellowish-green, which the fanciful [Poets] of the Walled Cities called chartreuse. Since Osthia preferred straightforward words, she called it yellowish-green.

Her scales were a bright yellow, and the spines on the crest of her head were dyed bright blue. It made her stand out, more than her wings already did. In fairness, Osthia could have been the most non-descript green color imaginable and she still would have stood out in any crowd.

Because of the wings. Osthia was a Drake, a Drake [Soldier], in fact, and she had wings. Some Humans might indeed say, 'a Drake with wings?

What's special about that? Don't all Drakes have wings?' and thereby prove to a listener that they were not only ignorant, but had never actually seen a Drake before. Or if they had, they'd only seen Osthia.

Because Drakes didn't have wings. Most of them didn't, anyways. Oh, sure, once upon a time when Dragons still flew about and burned cities to the ground and Drakes were young, they had wings. But now Drakes were wingless. They didn't breathe fire anymore either. At least, most of them didn't.

Osthia didn't breathe fire. But she could do something just as unpleasant if she felt like it. Two of the [Soldiers] in her company could breathe fire though, and one could just breathe smoke, which was...something.

Now Osthia stood in the snow, back straight, tail brushing snow off of the ground. She wished she'd put on a tail warmer, but that would have been unprofessional. Tail armor, now, that would be nice. Padded for warmth...Osthia sighed, and then straightened up further as she saw two figures riding towards them in the snow. At last! She took a breath and then shouted.

“Company, *attention!*”

The Drakes around her immediately stood straighter. Each one looked forwards, holding their arms at the ready if they were carrying longer weapons. Osthia held her spear by her side, staring ahead.

Each Drake in Osthia's company was wearing ornate, embellished armor. Nothing fancy; nothing that would detract from the use of the armor, but each one had a noticeable sigil, crest, or other nod to their bloodline. If the Drake couldn't afford the armor, they were provided with specialized gear.

Theirs was a unique group. They weren't necessarily an elite group of high-level warriors, but they were well-trained, well-equipped, and prestigious. You couldn't just join this company. You had to be born to it.

“At ease, Captain Osthia.”

General Thrissiam dismounted from his mare and handed the reins to a waiting soldier as he strode over to the company of Drakes. He smiled briefly at Osthia and she returned the smile. They were family and that

much was allowed. Then her attention turned to the other [General], the one leading the second army sent to kill the Goblin Lord.

Osthia didn't know who she'd been expecting, but a Gnoll wasn't it. She was an officer though, and she immediately recognized one of the more prominent Gnoll [Generals] on the continent.

"General Garusa, this is Captain Osthia Blackwing and the Ancestor Guard company assigned to me. I hope to make use of their abilities to locate and engage the Goblin Lord."

The tall female Gnoll smiled at Osthia and then sniffed the air as she looked across the ranks of assembled Drakes. A lot of Gnolls did that when first meeting Osthia or someone from her company. They probably smelled something quite unique.

"Ah. Oldblood soldiers. I am impressed, Thrissiam."

Did it bother Osthia that this Gnoll was speaking so informally with Thrissiam already? A bit. But she didn't shift her position. She was a soldier, and disciplined. She lead this company—she had worked hard for this place! It wasn't just because of her heritage that she'd earned her rank, either.

Oldblood. That was the correct term for what Osthia and the rest of the Drakes in her company were. The incorrect term was whatever you wanted it to be, but it was wise to be wary of saying that around any Drake with the old blood. Because you might get a face full of fire or lightning in reply.

Osthia had wings. Most of the Drakes in the Oldblood company didn't. Some had only vestigial stumps, or half-formed wings. But some had none at all. Those Drakes could breathe fire. Or lightning. Or mist. Or something else entirely. They could do this, what no other Drakes could, because they had more of their ancestor's blood in their veins. These Drakes, Osthia included, remembered a part of what it was like to be a Dragon.

Less than one in a thousand Drakes had a hint of their ancestry in their veins. Any family could give birth to someone with the old blood, but families with pure bloodlines that went back to the dawn of the Drake species were far more likely to have a child with the old blood. Such individuals were cherished, and the families often given money and aid for simply raising them.

There was prestige in being of the old blood, oh yes. It was easier to get a job in any position, and in some circles having a drop of the old blood was as good as a noble title. Better. And this was a company of the Oldblood Drakes. As good as a company of mages, in theory.

It was one of the things that separated the Walled Cities from the lesser Drake city-states. Only a Walled City had the population and the pure bloodlines to field an entire battalion of such warriors. Only a company had been sent to accompany General Thrissiam, but it was a mark of the trust placed in him by the city of Pallass that they'd sent anyone at all. None of the Oldblood had been sent with Wall Lord Ilvriss in his dispute with Zel Shivertail.

Of course, that also had much to do with the politics and dangers of sending a force against Zel Shivertail, who might well rip apart any group of soldiers sent against him. He was popular among the old families, although he'd taken a position in the Trisstral Allaince, which often butted heads with the Walled Cities.

In truth, Osthia preferred to fight Goblins anyways. Drakes fighting Drakes left a bad taste in her mouth, even when it was to settle a dispute.

"Blackwing? Hrr. Are you two related, General Thrissiam?"

Garusa addressed Thrissiam as she walked across the ranks of Drakes, inspecting their arms. Thrissiam nodded.

"Osthia is a relation of mine. I knew her growing up, and was pleased to be assigned her company for this campaign. You will not be disappointed with her performance."

"I have no doubt."

Osthia listened, watching Thrissiam out of the corner of one eye. She and he were indeed cousins. He was her uncle, technically, but they were only separated by ten years. And they were distant, very distant cousins. Practically strangers. Certainly no issue if they wanted to marry.

Osthia had liked Thrissiam ever since she'd met him as a hatchling. She hadn't ever told him that of course—but she had made every effort to be assigned to his command, regardless of what he was doing. Now she quelled the butterflies in her stomach as Thrissiam turned towards her.

“We’ll be striking camp soon, Captain Osthia. Have your soldiers ready to move. I would like you to join one of the scouting groups with those under your command able to fly.”

“Yes sir. I would be delighted to.”

She had to stop her tail from twitching as she smiled at General Thrissiam. That would have been a dead giveaway, and very embarrassing as well.

Garusa stopped next to Thrissiam, and Osthia’s smile vanished. She didn’t want the Gnoll to think she was approving of her just yet. In her opinion, Thrissiam should have been appointed command over both armies. He was a [General] from one of the Walled Cities, after all.

The Gnoll General nodded at Osthia, smiling without baring her teeth.

“I have never fought with the Oldblood before. Against them...on occasion. I am honored to fight alongside you, young Blackwing.”

“I hope to have the opportunity, General Garusa.”

The Gnoll nodded, and both she and Thrissiam left. Osthia waited until they were gone and then she and the Oldblood soldiers joined the rest of the army on the march. Osthia called for several names under her command, and then leapt into the air, wings beating. She *flew*.

It was a sight that made the Gnolls and Drakes in Garusa’s army look up and exclaim. Osthia, wearing chainmail and a helmet, not to mention holding a spear, flew above them, wings laboring to gain altitude in the frozen air.

She flew high into the sky with the six other Drakes who had wings. It was hard, very hard, to stay aloft for long. Osthia could feel the magic burning in her depleting itself with every wing beat. She was far too heavy to fly normally, and unless she sustained her flight with magic as Dragons did, she would be forced to land.

She couldn’t fly long. Nor could she use her breath weapon with impunity. Those with abilities stemming from their blood found it was often a curse as well as a blessing. Some Drakes grew faint of breath when they used their breath weapons, or injured their own throats. Osthia’s heritage

was true though, and she could use both her wings and her breath attack without issue.

She flew on, eyes peeled for any Goblins on the landscape below. The foolish creatures probably had no idea that a Drake could fly. But she didn't see a single Goblin below, although she was high enough to look around for miles.

Perhaps they weren't there? Goblins didn't strike Osthia as bright enough to hide or cover their tracks. Had their intelligence been mistaken? Was the Goblin Lord elsewhere?

Time would tell. Osthia was too experienced to trust to a quick view from the sky, although the lack of any signs of Goblins bothered her. It *could* be they were hiding, or farther away than she thought. And if this was a mistake? Well, she could use the opportunity to get closer to Thrissiam.

She was getting tired after only ten minutes of flight. Very tired. Osthia saw the other soldiers with wings flagging, and turned her head to order them to head back. As she did, she felt something crawl down her spine. A feeling, as if someone was staring at her with an arrow trained on her back.

Instantly, Osthia dove down. The other soldiers did likewise, moving instinctively to avoid an arrow or spell. Osthia turned and scanned the landscape. And saw nothing.

Was it a false alarm? For a minute, and then two she scanned the white slopes of the mountain, the trees, the rocks. And saw nothing. She raised her hand and signaled the other wary Drakes that it was a false alarm. She had seen nothing.

But the feeling remained. Something had been watching her, Osthia was sure of it. But whatever it was, it was already gone. Or hidden from her sight.

Rattled, Osthia flew back with her escort, landing safely among the ranks of her fellow soldiers. She abandoned her thoughts of romance. There *was* something out there. It was waiting for them. And so she and the army would flush it out.

And kill it.

Day 60

It was cold. Wet. Thrissiam kept the new joint army moving and scouting ahead. There were no signs of Goblins yet, although they'd covered a lot of ground, keeping their [Scouts] and groups of riders moving at all times.

"This damn snow came at the worst time for a Goblin Lord. It falls too heavily each day. Any tracks are being erased. Damn those Winter Sprites!"

He was grouching to Garusa, who he'd found was a worthy companion as they rode their army towards the next place they'd chosen to fortify and explore from. The Gnoll grinned.

"Perhaps the Goblins are having a courtly dance as we wait, hm? What must this Goblin Lord be like? Surely a Lord is a [Lord], Goblin or not."

She had a weird sense of humor too. Thrissiam snorted despite himself. He knew a [Lord] could be specialized in combat or managing his lands depending on how their Skills were gained. Thus, some Human [Lords] could counter the greatest Drake [Generals], like the Human Lord Tyrior. But most were inferiors to a class dedicated towards battle like his.

"I suppose you think all [Lords] dance? Take it from me, Weatherfur, some of the Lords—and Ladies—of the Wall are just as adept at sword dances as they are at ballroom dancing."

"Hrr. Then why are they not here? Was there not a Lord of the Wall that fought General Shivertail a month ago? He could be a match for this Goblin Lord."

"Catch a Lord of the Wall doing a mission like this? Not likely. They're for quick glory and guts, not a slog or hunt."

Thrissiam lashed his tail, and Garusa smiled. Their army continued onwards, watchful, vigilant. The first of the [Scouts] began disappearing a few hours later.

Day 61

Osthia flew a patrol with the six Drakes in her command. She flew high as she could, drinking a mana potion to replenish her energy. It was a foul-

tasting brew, despite the quality. Osthia hated using it, for all it let her fly longer. She could only do so four times before she'd start throwing up, a sure sign of overdosing on the stuff.

Today she was escorting a group of [Scouts], overseeing three groups in fact, as they roamed the forest searching for signs of life. So far they'd found nothing. No monsters, and there had to have been some about in this wooded area.

But they'd found nothing. And yesterday, twelve of the Gnolls and Drakes sent out had failed to come back over the course of the day. They'd vanished, each time alone, each time far from the main army.

Thrissiam had suspected Goblins, but larger groups hadn't found any traces of a struggle. So he'd sent Osthia to watch from above. So she did. She flew and watched. One scout group exited the forest and entered a clearing where they paused, investigating something on the ground. Another vanished below a dense canopy of leaves. The third scaled a cliff side.

Watch. Osthia saw the group in the clearing turn away from what they'd been looking at. The group on the cliff headed higher. The group under the canopy...

Didn't emerge. Osthia waited a minute, and then two. Something was wrong. She immediately put a horn to her lips and blew a horn call. She blew five blasts, attracting both groups of [Scouts]. They signed towards her and she pointed in the direction of the missing group.

Behind her, more horn calls sounded. Osthia listened and heard drumbeats as well, beating out a pattern. A group of riders was already headed for her spot, and the drums were telling her to *hold position*.

Osthia ignored the order. She turned to the flying Drakes and pointed with her spear.

"*Down!* Be ready for anything. Rass—stay back and watch! If we're not out in a second—"

She was already diving with the others. Osthia *crashed* through the branches, ready to use her breath weapon, spear ready. She was expecting anything—

And found nothing. Nothing. Just a messed up section of snow. No [Scouts], no Goblins. Nothing.

They'd been taken out in the few minutes since the alarm was sounded. Warily, Osthia looked around. She felt something watching her. The Drakes in her command spread out around her. If the Goblins had taken the [Scouts]—

“Up! Into the air!”

She cried out and the Drakes leapt back up, swearing, crashing through branches. Now Osthia circled wide, searching for anything moving in the trees. But she found nothing. Neither did the riders, or the [Scouts]. They combed the landscape, but whatever had taken this group of [Scouts] had just vanished into the air.

Day 62

They knew there were Goblins about. For three days now, their patrols had been ambushed. Smaller ones, ones that strayed too far, simply vanished. The others found nothing. It set all of Thrissiam's scales on edge, and so he'd refused to budge from the second hilltop. Instead, he was sending out larger scouting groups with [Mages] to look for traces of the Goblins.

Now he stood in his command tent, staring at the map of the landscape, irritated, on edge. His army was camped on the top of the hill, giving them a view of the surroundings. A nearby mountain loomed over them, and a forest surrounded their position to the northwest. He looked up as someone opened the tent flap. Thrissiam was about to order whoever it was out, but he bit his tongue as Garusa entered.

“Any word?”

She shook her head.

“Another patrol came back with no findings. None at all. It is odd, yes? They should have found some sign of what attacked the last, but none did. Not the [Mages] and experienced [Scouts].”

“Magic. Or something else. Damn it!”

Thrissiam pounded the table with his claws, taking care not to damage the map. He wasn't used to this. Not from *Goblins*. He'd be wary if another force managed to elude him, but how were Goblins doing this? Was this really all due to a Goblin Lord? Garusa watched him for a moment before speaking.

"I had a thought."

"Share it."

"When we met I wondered why the Goblin Lord would retreat here. There is no food for his army, and Goblins devour. It is a bad choice, for one that knows an attack is coming, no?"

"That's true."

Thrissiam nodded, still angry but thinking now. Garusa nodded as well.

"Yes, a smarter decision would be to raid other cities, to keep moving, growing an army by collecting other Goblins nearby. So why hide?"

"To buy time, or maybe traverse the mountains? What's your point?"

Garusa sniffed. She frowned, but kept speaking.

"It makes no sense. Goblin Lords know they will be hunted. So perhaps..."

"Perhaps what?"

Thrissiam looked up at Garusa. Her face was shadowed, her voice low.

"Perhaps the Goblin Lord only retreated to make sure it was *we* who could not run. I smell Goblins, Thrissiam. I smell them everywhere, but cannot find their scent. And the smell is *everywhere*."

He stared at her. Her eyes gleamed. Thrissiam opened his mouth, and then heard a horn call in the distance. It was blaring the call to attack. He jerked upright, and then heard another from the west. And another.

And another.

The last one was blowing right outside. Thrissiam stormed out, Garusa following, and heard the screams.

"Sound the alarm! We're under attack!"

He looked out, and suddenly the barren landscape was filled with motion. Goblins boiled down the slopes from the mountains, charged out of the forest, shouting, screaming. Hundreds, *thousands* of them.

“Recall all forces! Rally on me!”

Thrissiam had his spear in his hands. He ran towards the front as Garusa called for her mount. The Goblins smashed into the fortifications his army had built, screaming. There were Hobs, Goblin [Mages]—the undead!

So many of them. Too many. And where was the Goblin Lord? Thrissiam was too busy fighting to see.

They came out of nowhere. One second Osthia had been resting her wings in camp, the next, the Goblins had poured out of the trees, down the mountain. Some burst out of the snow.

Out of the snow?

“To arms! Goblin attack!”

The cry went up as Osthia ran towards the front. There was no time to find her company. She just fell into line with the [Soldiers] around her. Drakes had learned to adapt to any situation.

But this was unnerving even so. The Goblins were *everywhere*. It wasn’t just that they’d snuck up on the army—they’d completely caught them off-guard! As Osthia watched, a completely flattened portion of ground suddenly exploded upwards, and Goblins clawed their way up.

They’d been waiting underground? *How?* They couldn’t breathe down there! Unless—and then Osthia saw it. The gray skin, the rotten flesh. It wasn’t just Goblins emerging from under the snow, under the ground. It was Drakes too, and Gnolls. They were all pale, flesh gray and rotting, bloodless.

Zombies.

“Undead!”

The cry went up as all the pieces fell into place for Osthia. That was why the [Scouts] had vanished so quickly! That was why the Goblins couldn't be found! The main force was probably hiding, while the undead waited below, attacking and burying themselves without a trace. The Drake army had marched right into the middle of where they were hiding. And now—

Now the trap was sprung, and they were under assault from all sides.

The first group of living Goblins hit the camp from the west, charging down the mountain. Osthia heard the screams and sound of battle begin, but didn't falter. A surprise attack it might be, but the Goblins were no match for a Drake [Soldier]. She kept believing that right until she saw a group of eight Hobgoblins charge into the side of the [Soldiers] and start hacking Drakes and Gnolls apart.

Osthia's eyes widened as the Hobs appeared. There shouldn't be that many Hobs in a tribe! But there were so many in this army! They towered over the smaller Goblins, standing toe-to-toe with elite warriors.

And then the fighting hit their side. Not living Goblins. Dead ones.

A wave of zombies, several skeletons, and three Ghouls hit the Drakes that Osthia was positioned with. She caught one as it ran onto her spear, and the Drakes around her did the same. As they were fighting, Drakes with swords stepped forwards, cutting as the ones with pikes shoved their enemies back. [Archers] began raining arrows on the undead and a [Mage] unleashed a shower of lightning that made several undead *jerk* and fall down before getting up.

Lightning magic was a bad idea on the undead. Osthia snarled as she jabbed her spear. There was a strange, grey Goblin walking towards her. Just walking. It looked...different from the rest. Osthia had a bad feeling about it, and stabbed it in the chest. The Goblin didn't try to stop her, and her spear's head went right through where its heart should be.

The gray Goblin fell, gaping soundlessly. Then it *exploded*, sending shockwaves of force and black energy spiraling outwards. Osthia cried out and saw the undead nearest to the exploding Goblin simply *vanish* as the blast consumed them. The Drakes around her were thrown backwards, and

the undead swarmed them. Osthia got up, saw a Ghoul running at her, and opened her mouth.

She didn't breathe fire. Instead, Osthia *spat*. That was how she thought of it. The glands in her mouth shot a greenish spray towards the Ghoul. It charged right into the mist, and then began to *melt*. It felt no pain, but suddenly the Ghoul's eyes and part of its face were gone. It swung wildly, knocking a skeleton to the ground. Osthia ran the Ghoul through and then turned and spat again.

The undead caught by her attack lurched onwards, melting down, blinded. The Drakes near Osthia seized the opportunity and shakily reformed the battle line. Osthia wiped at her mouth, relieved that her body was immune to her ability. She turned her head and shouted at the nearest Drake [Sergeant].

"Take down the gray Goblins before they reach the camp! Spread the word! I'll tell the [General]! *Hurry!*"

She leapt into the air, flying back towards the center of camp. Now she could hear the *thump* as more of the trapped Goblins exploded, sowing chaos among the Drakes and Gnolls. Thrissiam heard her garbled report and immediately called for every [Archer] to prioritize the Goblins. The threat dealt with in part, Osthia found her company.

She led the next charge into the ranks of the living Goblins, who screamed as they felt her acid burn and eat at them. The ones around her fled, but more kept coming. More, and more. They didn't seem to fear death. They wore black armor and screamed in hatred as they kept coming.

An hour later, Osthia was pulling back, exhausted, barely able to move, when she saw him. As her company retreated and a fresh group of soldiers was rotated in, she caught sight of an oddity in the seething mass of Goblins.

At first, she thought it was just another Hob. But this one was different. He stood on a ledge hundreds of meters away from the fighting, on the mountainside. He was staring at the fighting armies, and as Osthia watched, his gaze passed over her.

For a moment, their eyes met. Osthia got only a glimpse of a Goblin's face. But something was wrong with his eyes. They weren't red.

Black eyes with white pupils. A piercing gaze. A hooded face. He stood among a group of Hobgoblins and Goblin [Mages] and [Shamans]. Just watching.

The Goblin Lord. Osthia was transfixed. She knew it was him the instant she saw him. No other Goblin was like him. His presence seemed to make him bigger, although he was only the size of a Human, not a towering mass like some of the Hobgoblins. He was only watching, but his eyes—Osthia felt dread.

Then he raised his arm and a black lance of light struck down one of the Drake [Mages] from behind. Osthia shouted, but the Goblin Lord was already turning away. He retreated out of danger as the Goblins roared and redoubled their efforts.

The Drakes and Gnolls held the line. They bled and died, but they pushed the Goblins and undead back. By the end of the day, the dead had stained the ground red, and churned mud froze overnight. That was the first day.

The second was just as bad.

Day 64

In the mountains, Drakes and Gnolls died. Goblins died. Everything died. Thrissiam led his army with Garusa against the Goblin Lord, cutting apart bodies, blasting enemy positions with magic, grappling with undead—

This was war with a Goblin Lord. And it was far more terrible than Thrissiam could have ever imagined.

The fighting wasn't a single day's affair. From morning until dusk, the Goblins assailed their position, fighting at dawn, at night, withdrawing, ambushing, trying to uproot the Drake army's position.

They hadn't managed to so far. But neither had the Drake army managed to force them back or deplete their numbers greatly. It was a deadlock. The Goblin Lord's full army outnumbered them greatly, but Thrissiam's forces were better equipped, better trained, higher level. It was a battle they could win, in short.

But some things made him uneasy. Garusa pointed it out the day after she'd carried Thrissiam into a bed. She had only shared it for an hour—the [Generals] were alternating shifts to keep up a steady defense. Now she and Thrissiam spoke concisely as Drakes tended to their injured with potions and wrapped wounds too light to warrant proper healing in a lull between the fighting.

“None of our [Mages] can cast the [Message] spell. They have tried each day, again and again, but the highest-level cannot.”

“So? We don't need reinforcements, and if we did, they'd be too late.”

Garusa nodded.

“Yes. That is true. But that is not what concerns me. To block the spell, so my [Mages] say, you would need a mage specialized in such magic...or a mage of far greater ability. Neither seems at home to a Goblin Lord's forces, no?”

That was true. Thrissiam frowned, suddenly worried.

“It might be they have an artifact. Or one of their [Shamans]...? You're right. It seems beyond them.”

“In that case, what is the cause?”

Thrissiam shook his head.

“I don't know. But we must get word back to the cities, no matter what happens. They have to know the Goblin Lord can use undead—and that he can block spells!”

Garusa nodded. Thrissiam's claws dug into the table.

“You were right. General Shivertail was right. That Goblin Lord...isn't ordinary. I see him out there, occasionally. In the trees, leading his forces. Never close enough that our [Marksmen] or [Snipers] could get a clear shot at him. And he blocked every spell my battle mages sent towards him.”

“We must try to hunt him down.”

“Yes. We'll try for it now. If it means sacrificing a group to have his head—”

“That is my job, no?”

He looked at her. They'd barely said a word in between sleeping together and waking. This was war. But he and she—he shook his head.

“Not yet. Not unless it comes to that. I won't risk you.”

She grinned at him, as if he'd made a joke.

“You are thinking with your head, not with your second tail, yes? A [General] must be composed and think of victory, not affection.”

Thrissiam went scarlet and looked around, but the tent was empty. He glared at Garusa.

“I'm thinking with my head. You are an asset that can't be replaced. We'll need you after this battle.”

He stared at the map as Garusa chuckled. The Goblin Lord's eyes. Where had he heard of eyes like that before? Necromancy. An uneasy surmise crept into Thrissiam's mind. He murmured.

“Yes. I think we might need everyone after this. Perhaps the Goblin Lord...isn't alone.”

Garusa stopped laughing. She met his eyes, and Thrissiam knew she had suddenly thought of the same thing. In the silence, they heard the fighting begin again.

Her eyes blurred with tears, although no one noticed her face in the fighting. Osthia spat acid at the Goblins who charged her, shot the concentrated, corrosive liquid into green faces and red eyes and heard the screams. It felt as though she were spitting the bile and pain out of her own stomach.

She had an endless supply.

Thrissiam and Garusa. Garusa and Thrissiam. It was like one of those silly songs the children sang. *Garusa and Thrissiam, tails in a knot!*

She lashed out and a Goblin fell, gurgling. This wasn't the time for such thoughts! And yet, the image followed her. Garusa carrying Thrissiam into

the tent after recovering him from the thick of battle and then—*not* emerging.

Every soldier knew what had happened. No judgment was passed. In fact, there was quite a lot of ribald support, muttered quietly and joked about when neither [General] could hear. Thrissiam because he'd order the jokester punished. Garusa because she might join in.

War made for very intimate choices, and many soldiers left what happened in the heat of things behind. But Osthia couldn't.

What had she expected? He was her distant relative, a [*General*] and practically nobility in himself! But she'd hoped, in that secret heart of hers...

Osthia took to the air, ignoring the warning calls from below. The Goblins were firing? Let them. She had practiced to avoid flights of arrows. She dove into the ranks of Goblins, spitting acid, hearing them shriek. Good! Let them die.

Then she saw the Goblin Lord. He was watching again, far away from the fighting. He always did that. He'd appear, blast the lines with magic, and then disappear. Not this time.

Osthia went for him. She knew it was foolhardy. She didn't care. She made it halfway before a flight of arrows rose up and magic blasted a hole straight through her wings.

She fell into the ranks of Goblins. The fall didn't kill her, but Osthia was trapped behind the lines, desperately spitting acid and sweeping around her with her spear. She would have died there, wanted to die there, but then she heard the horn call.

A Gnoll on horseback charged into the ranks of Goblins with a group of mounted riders, trampling the smaller ones, lashing out left and right. She made straight towards Osthia, cutting a path through her enemies. Garusa Weatherfur's paws were a blur as she struck left and right, clearing a path for Osthia to survive.

Both she and Thrissiam used a spear. It was just another reason to hate her as Garusa swept the Goblins around her away. She dueled a Hobgoblin, ending it by thrusting her long spear through his helmetless face while

Osthia struggled to stand. Then Garusa took Osthia's clawed hand and pulled her into the saddle. She rode back towards their line as a cheer went up from the Drakes.

It didn't make Osthia hate her any less. But it did make her respect the Gnoll as a [General]. Garusa was necessary, vital. She was a hero.

Osthia just wished Garusa hadn't also taken her dream away.

"Fool!"

Thrissiam struck Osthia across the face. She took the blow, cheek burning, as he shouted at her.

"You endangered your life and cost us good soldiers going to save you! What were you thinking?"

"I have no excuse, sir."

"Calm yourself, Thrissiam."

"General Garusa. With respect—"

"She took a chance and went for the Goblin Lord. I might have done so as well were I in her place. Now we know he is waiting for the moment, yes?"

The hole in her wing was mended. The hole in her heart...it hurt more to hear Garusa defend her. That wasn't why Osthia had gone, but she couldn't bring herself to say so. Thrissiam calmed himself in the end. When he spoke to her next, it was curtly, but not without affection.

"Rest yourself. I will have orders tomorrow. You are to do nothing that is not ordered, is that understood?"

"Yes, General."

Officers had been declared treasonous for disobeying orders. Osthia knew she was getting off lucky. But she still felt wretched. After a moment, Thrissiam spoke quietly to her.

“You are a treasure of our people, and of our family as well. I could not bear to see you die in some meaningless charge.”

It was meant for the two of them. Garusa busied herself across the tent, although Osthia knew she could hear everything. It helped, a bit. Osthia smiled weakly at Thrissiam.

“Thank you, sir.”

He studied her, and then nodded. Grimly, Thrissiam turned back to the map.

“I don’t blame you for trying. This Goblin Lord is dangerous. If we don’t stop him now, there’s no telling how dangerous he might get.”

“He is new, yet. But if he gathers more Goblins, or raises more undead...”

“It won’t happen.”

Osthia watched as Garusa and Thrissiam’s eyes met over the table. They were alike, in that way. She stumbled out of the tent and cried for a bit in her tent. Then she woke up and went back to war.

Day 65

“The undead.”

That was what would kill them, Thrissiam knew. Looking at the map of the battlefield, he felt as though he understood the flow of how things would go. Numbers, supplies, levels of soldiers and geography, it all flowed into a picture in his mind. The scales were balanced; he had his advantages, and the Goblin Lord his. But what tipped the balance were the undead.

Because for every Drake and Gnoll that fell, a zombie could rise in its place. Or worse, a Ghoul.

So far, the Goblins and the Goblin Lord had only managed to animate a few of the fallen Drakes and Gnolls of Thrissiam’s force. So far. But as time wore on, the Drake knew that the natural spawning of the undead as well as the efforts of the Goblin Lord and his [Necromancers] would slowly increase that number.

“We can’t make this a battle of attrition any longer. The Goblin Lord overplayed his claw at first, and gave us the opportunity to tear into his forces. But he’s pulling back, wearing us down with numbers rather than commit his Hobs and [Mages] to the front. We need to either pull them out, or take him down.”

Standing across the table from him, Garusa nodded. She had a long gash down one cheek, splitting her fur and exposing red, but she had forgone healing it to save potions. It might damage the morale of the soldiers to see their general injured, but the situation called for it.

“I agree. We must corner him. But how?”

“I propose an ambush. We know he has a forward camp here and here. He alternates between the two before pulling back.”

“True. You suggest ambushing him? We could strike a wedge here, cutting him off—”

“And then encircle his position. Yes.”

Thrissiam had observed the Goblin Lord over the course of the battle. The Goblin had played things safe, attacking only from a distance with magic. But he had shown a predictability in how he moved, and revealed that it was possible to predict where he’d go. In short, he’d given Thrissiam a perfect opportunity to corner him.

“He may be a Goblin Lord, but he’s new to it. An amateur is still an amateur, even with Skills.”

The Drake grinned savagely. Garusa’s smile was no less predatory.

“Tomorrow?”

“No sense waiting for it. Keep up the front; don’t let him think we’re doing anything. I’ll pull together all the elites I can. They’ll be under your command.”

Garusa nodded.

“I will prepare.”

Thrissiam caught her as she was about to leave the tent.

“Don’t fight him if you think he’ll win. We can try again if we must. But I can’t lose you.”

She blinked at him, wide-eyed. Then she smiled.

“Too much thinking with your other tail. I will do what needs to be done. And I will bring you the Goblin Lord’s head tomorrow, my word on it. Unless I squish it by accident, that is.”

She kissed him, and left. Thrissiam turned back to the map, and began to plan for the end.

Day 66

The Goblin Lord never saw the attack coming. In fairness, he did see the feint, and then the charge that went deep into his army’s left flank, aimed at a group of his [Necromancers]. When he appeared and blasted the soldiers with magic from a distance, the Drakes launched two other charges, penetrating the lines of shocked Goblins with an elite group of soldiers. They cut the Goblin Lord’s retreat off, and then the last group formed up, aimed straight for the Goblin Lord’s throat as his retinue struggled to fend off the sudden offensive.

Thrissiam watched Garusa charge. He had committed over half the army to the push in the end, holding the rest of the Goblin Lord’s forces at bay with a thin line of his own. It was a tactic only two [Generals] could pull off and Thrissiam used every Skill to make sure there was a place to return to for Garusa.

Now all he could do was watch. The Gnoll [General] charged through Goblins and Hobgoblins alike, tearing through them with a guard of elite riders, protected by mage spell and raining arrows.

The Goblin Lord’s personal guard met her force with a roar that echoed through the battlefield. Thrissiam watched, as from above, Osthia dove and showered the group with acid. Garusa used that opportunity to strike down a [Mage]. And then—

A black lance of magic. The Gnoll twisted in her saddle, dodging the magic. It killed her stallion, leaving only half of its head. The horse went down, but then Garusa was charging the Goblin Lord.

“Yes. Do it!”

Thrissiam's claws were clenched. He could see the Goblin Lord's surprise, see two Hobs barring the way with huge halberds. A [Mage] struck one with lightning—Osthia speared the other in the back from above. And then Garusa was face-to-face with the Goblin Lord.

His eyes were wide, disbelieving. The Goblin Lord's face was twisted in a snarl. He held a black blade in one hand, shimmering magic in the other as he faced Garusa. The Drakes and Gnolls around Thrissiam were cheering wildly, sure of victory. But there was fear in Thrissiam's heart. And something else.

Uneasiness. It wasn't easy. This was the culmination of strategy, of superior planning and teamwork. They had whittled the Goblin Lord's forces and played on his confidence to come this far.

But something was wrong. Garusa raised her spear, slashing at the Goblin Lord. He stepped back, warily. She twirled her spear and advanced. He lashed out with magic—she dodged. Closer now. She struck out—

And Thrissiam heard a voice.

"Fool."

It was a whisper, but it reached across the battlefield. Garusa's spear struck a white wall that shot from the ground. A wall as smooth and pale as ivory.

Bone.

Something changed. The wall of bone retracted into the ground as Garusa leapt back. When Thrissiam could see the Goblin Lord again, he was standing in the same place.

But something else was wearing his body. The Goblin Lord stood still, and when his lips moved, every Drake and Gnoll and Goblin could hear his voice.

"You have disappointed me, my apprentice. I should not have to intercede on your behalf."

Garusa was staring at the Goblin Lord. Thrissiam tried to shout at her, but the dark voice was overpowering everything else. He tried to scream to her to run, but the Gnoll crouched. She came in low, fast—

“So be it. I will rectify your mistake.”

The Goblin Lord raised a hand. And Garusa—crumpled.

It was just a flash of light. A black bolt of energy that went through her chest. Thrissiam screamed. The Goblin Lord turned his hand. Pointed.

“Despair.”

A black scythe shot out, cutting through the ranks of soldiers that had followed Garusa. Not just through them, through Goblins as well. Bodies crumpled to the floor, dead. Lifeless. Everybody in two hundred meters in the direction the Goblin Lord had pointed fell. And then—

“Rise.”

They rose. Unsteadily, getting to their feet. Garusa stood up, and for a second, Thrissiam dared to hope—then her head turned and he saw the hole in her chest. And the light in her eyes.

The undead, half of his army and the Goblin Lord’s—stared towards the remaining soldiers. Their eyes shone, and they began to walk, and then to run. They charged back towards their former comrades.

“Now finish this.”

The voice spoke once more, and then the Goblin Lord was stumbling as other Goblins rushed to his side. Thrissiam stared at him, and then at the undead.

Thousands of them, ten thousand—twenty—each and every corpse on the battlefield had risen all at once. And now they came for his army. The Drakes and Gnolls, steadfast warriors, cried out and broke ranks, retreating.

“No.”

“Uncle! Uncle!”

Someone was screaming his name. Above. Thrissiam looked up. Osthia flew down towards him, wounded, bleeding. Her face was pale, her eyes filled with tears.

“He—it—”

He’d sent all of the Oldblood soldiers with her. Six had gone, none had returned. There was an arrow in one of Osthia’s wings. Now more

showered down around Thrissiam as the Goblin army redoubled its attack.

He stared at her blankly. Then at the undead. They were coming. So many. Enough to bury what remained of his army. And Garusa—she was out there too.

“We’ve lost.”

There was nothing hard in saying it. Osthia’s eyes widened. Thrissiam went on.

“We lost the moment we failed to understand. It wasn’t him. We shouldn’t have just feared him. It was who was controlling him. Do you understand?”

He looked at Osthia.

“The Necromancer.”

She paled.

“But he’s dead.”

“Not anymore.”

Thrissiam turned. His officers were staring in shock, paralyzed by what had happened.

“*Scouts! Runners!*”

Thrissiam bellowed. He could still do that. His voice snapped some out of their fog. They looked towards him. Thrissiam saw some turning, coming towards him. No time.

“Run!”

They stared at him. Thrissiam pointed, south, the way they had come.

“*Run!* Go to the cities! Warn them! Go! Now!”

No time to tell them. If they were smart, the others would figure it out. Thrissiam pointed and shouted. He saw Drakes and Gnolls dashing for the trees, running past Goblins, trying to escape as the Goblin Lord’s army came from every side.

“Uncle—are you—”

Thrissiam turned to Osthia. Her eyes were wide. She probably didn't realize she was calling him Uncle. He nearly laughed. He wasn't old enough to be her uncle.

What a silly thing to think of. Thrissiam smiled at Osthia as he gave her his last order.

"You too, Osthia. Go. Fly away. Tell them who the real enemy is."

"I can't! I can't abandon—"

"Go. There's no point in dying here. You are the pride of Drakes. My family. You have to tell them."

She refused, shaking. The undead were coming. Thrissiam's eyes were on them. On the Goblin Lord. He was falling back, carried by his soldiers. Osthia was trying to stay.

"Go."

"Drakes do not run!"

He turned to her.

"I know. Hurry up and come back soon."

He smiled. Osthia's eyes widened. She opened her mouth to object, and saw the mass of undead charging towards them. For a second she looked into his eyes, and Thrissiam thought she saw his broken heart. Her eyes filled with tears. Without a word, she took wing.

"I'll be back! Hold out! Retreat!"

She screamed at him as she fled eastward. Thrissiam saw Goblins shouting and some firing on her, others breaking away to chase after the lone flying Drake. He prayed she'd get away. But the cruel, cold part of him knew that she was too obvious a target. The [Scouts] and [Runners] he'd sent might have a chance if the Goblins were distracted.

She was his niece. He had grudgingly played with her and his younger cousins when he visited. When she was older, he had taught her to use a spear. He had accepted her into his army, presented her with her first promotion. He'd never spoken of her eyes on his back, preserved her dreams like a precious thing. And now he had sent her to die.

But that was her duty. And his. For their people, no cost could be too high. Thrissiam saluted Osthia with his spear and then turned to the undead. His [Soldiers]. He looked for Garusa's body among them. There she was. Leading the charge as always.

Her eyes were glowing. Thrissiam felt something hard grab at his soul, demanding vengeance. Pain was in his blood. He looked at Garusa as she ran like lightning across the ground. Too fast! She was no Ghoul. Her body was infused with more than just unholy quickness and a taste for flesh. She was too strong, sweeping experienced soldiers away, hurling a Gnoll in plate armor into the air and tearing an arm straight off of a Drake [Pikeman].

Not a Wight. Her touch wasn't paralysis and she was too tough. Thrissiam's pulse quickened as he realized what she had become.

A Draugr. One of the higher levels of undead. Not one with tricks like a Wight, or an amalgamation of souls like a Crypt Lord, but a version of the undead that was akin to a zombie. But only a truly high-level [Necromancer] could think of animating one.

There was more than one Draugr in the ranks of the undead. They smashed into Thrissiam's remaining army, overrunning groups of pikes, barricades, too strong and tough to stop. The Drake heard cries for help, but he had only eyes for Garusa.

"Go, Osthia. Tell them the Goblin Lord has a master. Tell them. Tell them it's the Necromancer. He's still alive. Go. Bring back a hundred armies. Bring back Shivertail. Bring the Tidebreaker! Bring them all and cleanse this land of his taint."

He met her as she charged at him, mouth agape. She struck him in the chest, and he stabbed through her armor. His enchanted spear met no resistance.

"You should have worn better armor."

He plunged the spear deep into Garusa's heart. She kept moving, and tore off something on his leg. Through his armor! Her claws were razors. Thrissiam nearly fell, but he took a grip on his spear.

"[Crescent Arc]!"

His spear *tore* through her flesh as it moved in the shape of a moon. Garusa stopped moving. Thrissiam looked away, and then forced his eyes down. She—

Something struck him from the side. A Ghoul tore at the [General] and he roared, throwing it off and spearing it through the head. Then he turned his eyes towards a fleeing shape on the horizon. Thrissiam smiled just once.

“Go. I’ll be waiting.”

He stood over Garusa’s corpse, spear whirling. The undead closed around him. Thrissiam killed them one by one, until something tore his spear away. Then he fought with his claws, his teeth. And then they bit him, tore at his flesh, broke his armor.

He fell and died, holding a Gnoll in his broken arms.

An hour later, his corpse rose and walked away, leaving a Gnoll behind, surrounded by corpses too damaged to use. What remained of General Thrissiam slowly lurched after the Goblins as they ransacked his camp, and then headed north. Not to Liscor.

Farther still.

Day 67

They captured Osthia not ten minutes after she left Thrissiam to die. She cursed them, spat acid, tried to fly with arrows and holes in her wings. They grabbed her, muzzled her like a dog and beat her until she saw nothing.

When she woke, it was in a tent. She was shackled, but her gag had been removed. She recognized the tent. It was Thrissiam’s.

But he did not stand there. Instead, the Goblin Lord stood in the center of the tent. Talking.

With himself.

Osthia’s first instinct was to breathe acid, but then she heard the voice. The same voice that had killed Garusa, that had brought the dead to life. It was coming from the Goblin Lord’s mouth.

“You are a disappointment. With all that I have taught you, defeating two armies should have been a simple task.”

What was happening? Who was speaking? Osthia pretended to be unconscious as she listened. The Goblin Lord growled, spat. Then he spoke, in a voice that was less well-educated, more direct. His voice.

“Strong Drakes. Strong Gnoll. Worthy foes.”

Something like a sigh emanated from his mouth as the other voice spoke. Osthia watched, shuddering.

“You alerted them to your greatest weapon and failed to use it to proper effect. You should have placed the Goblins among your own forces and unleashed them deep within the enemy ranks when they least expected it. You could easily have obliterated the army’s most elite warriors in the opening engagement if you had done so. Instead, you wasted them by confining the undead and your Goblins to separate groups.”

“Cannot kill own—”

“Foolish.”

The word sent shivers down her spine.

“If you want victory, you must sacrifice. Next time, place the Goblins among your force. Do not fail me this time. Unify the Goblins, my apprentice. Or perish in despair.”

The presence receded. The Goblin Lord stumbled as the other person left him. He turned, and hurled the table that Thrissiam had planned the battle over to one side. Osthia sat up.

“You.”

The Goblin Lord turned, eyes widening.

Now. Osthia spat. A stream of acid shot upwards, pressurized liquid spurting into the Goblin Lord’s face. She waited for him to scream, but heard no sound. Instead she saw the liquid splash his body and drip from an invisible surface surrounding his entire body.

Calmly, the Goblin Lord wiped Osthia’s acid away and scattered it to the ground, where the soil steamed and melted. He glanced down at Osthia as she stared wide-eyed at him and then spoke.

“Ring of Protection. And [Ward of Repulsion]. I could have taken the Gnoll’s charge.”

His voice was so normal. That was what was shocking. It was...it wasn’t like the Necromancer’s voice. But it was no guttural mumbling. It was educated, thoughtful. That scared Osthia most of all.

“Kill me. Or do what you want. You’ll get no secrets out of me.”

She was prepared to bite her tongue, to try and attack the Goblin Lord again. Osthia wanted to die. She was ready for it. She wasn’t ready for the Goblin Lord to laugh.

“Kill you? You and I...we have the same enemy. You will help me.”

“Never.”

He grinned at her, his black eyes and white pupils staring into hers. Osthia shuddered. The Goblin Lord noticed and tapped one eye.

“He sees when he looks. He does not look now.”

“The Necromancer.”

“Yes.”

Something twisted the Goblin Lord’s face. He suddenly looked angry. But he was the Necromancer’s apprentice. And yet—

“Tell me about him. All your people know.”

“What?”

She stared at him. Osthia looked into the Goblin Lord’s eyes. She felt the oddity of his question, realized the dissonance in how he acted and spoke before. The same enemy? Did that mean—

The Goblin Lord found a chair and pushed it towards Osthia. He was nothing like she had expected. He looked down at her, tall, gaunt, eyes filled with dark secrets. And fury. He gestured and she saw a dead Goblin standing by the tent’s entrance. She hadn’t noticed him.

Her. It was a female Goblin. A child. The undead zombie swayed in place, lifeless. The Goblin Lord went over to her. He made her turn to Osthia and bared his teeth.

“My subject. My master created her. Killed her to make a weapon. All for me. So tell me. Who is he? What is he? He is my enemy in time. You are. Your people are. But he is most of all. Tell me.”

He stared at her, eyes filled with helpless fury. Osthia felt the certainty of the world begin to shift. The Goblin Lord’s eyes burned.

“Tell me about the Necromancer.”

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4.17

Ryoka stood in the darkness, heart pounding. She was afraid. Mortally afraid. There were things she feared in the world, and she was about to face one of them.

She had met Dragons, [Necromancers], Goblin Lords, and yes, each one was terrifying in a way that left scars on the soul. If she closed her eyes, she could still taste the fear. Such memories weren't nightmarish, though. Nightmares were generally figments of the dreaming mind, and as such, couldn't come close to the experience of seeing a Dragon face to face.

Part of the fear was wonder. And when Ryoka sat up at night, heart pounding, seeing the Goblins slaughtering the Stone Spears tribe, feeling her fingers *bitten off*—

That was a horror, one that did not disappear for waking. Because a nightmare was only suspicion, paranoia, unfulfilled fear. Goblins existed. The Goblin Lord was coming. So was the [Necromancer], and Ryoka didn't know what to do.

All these traumas—Ryoka hadn't even included dead things around a fire, or evil carnivorous goats. With so much to be afraid of in this world, it seemed silly to have this fear.

And yet, it stemmed from a different place than the ordeals she had gone through. This one was personal, intimate, and it came from a time when Ryoka had been in her world. She just couldn't face it without shuddering inside.

She *hated* visiting friends. Or to be more accurate, she thought she did. She'd never actually done it.

Until now.

Ryoka hesitated outside of the door of the large farmhouse. By her side, Mrsha fidgeted in the snow. She looked plaintively up at Ryoka as her stomach rumbled.

It was dark. That didn't necessarily mean late; winter being what it was, the sun had gone down before it was time for dinner. And that was why

Ryoka was here.

Dinner at Garia's. She'd asked, and Garia had been only too happy to talk to her parents. And of course, Fals had agreed to come and Ryoka had known it was the only good thing to do as a friend. Still...

It was going to be *awkward*. Ryoka dreaded that. She didn't know what to do, what to say, how to act, and she had a horrible fear of silence at the dinner table. At other people's dinner tables, that was. Her naturally antagonistic relationship with her parents had made her accustomed to it at her house, on the rare occasions they all ate together.

But there was no help for it. Ryoka had taken Mrsha from Erin's inn after Safry and Maran had been fired. She'd gone to Celum and run with the Gnoll carried on her back. There was actually a kind of basket the Gnolls used that could be used to carry their young. It wasn't exactly easy to run with, but Ryoka had crossed through snow and run down empty roads until she reached a farm a few miles west of Celum.

That had surprised her, learning that Garia lived so close by. But she'd never talked to the girl about her family, aside from the basics. Garia lived on a farm. Her parents ran said farm. That was all Ryoka needed to know.

And the farm did seem like a proper...farm. It was hard to see in the darkness, but Ryoka had spotted a structure very similar to a barn coming in. It seemed quite large to be run by just two people. Maybe they hired help? Anyways, it didn't fit with what Ryoka had expected. She wasn't sure *what* she'd expected.

"And now we're here. I should have asked more questions. Like do I bring a gift? I'm pretty sure a hungry Gnoll isn't a normal hostess gift."

Ryoka muttered to herself. By her side, Mrsha looked up imploringly. Ryoka had been standing outside in the snow for a *minute*, which in Mrsha time was probably a year. The Gnoll was clearly hungry—she could probably smell the food inside. She edged over to Ryoka and poked her leg with a claw, looking meaningfully at the door.

"In a second, Mrsha."

She just had to steel herself. Okay, say 'hi, thanks for having me'. Or did she introduce herself first? Ryoka hesitated. Maybe she should—

“Just go in, you daft coward!”

Someone shouted in her ear. Then Ivolethe kicked Ryoka in the back of the head.

“Ow.”

Ryoka swatted at the Frost Faerie. Ivolethe flew around her and glared at Ryoka.

“Stop dithering. I grow bored with every passing moment ye stay out here, and my kind watches *trees* grow for sport.”

The Frost Faerie stared meaningfully at Ryoka. She’d come with Ryoka on the journey, amusing Mrsha to no end by tormenting Ryoka with flurries of snow, snowballs, snow pitfalls, and other winter-related pranks. Ryoka opened her mouth to snap back, felt another poke, and gave in after a short fight.

“Okay, okay. Stop kicking me—stop *poking* me, Mrsha. I know it’s you. Don’t look around. There’s no one else here! I’m doing it.”

Steeling herself, she raised her hand and knocked loudly at the door. Ryoka had heard muffled sounds from within, and there were lights burning behind the shuttered windows. Now, at her knock, she heard a loud exclamation from within and heavy, running footsteps.

“Ryoka!”

The door burst open. Mrsha nearly went flying as Garia flung the door wide and then engulfed Ryoka in a bone-crushing hug.

“Gah! Garia!”

“It’s so great you’re here! Oh! And Mrsha! I didn’t see you there! Hello! Remember me?”

She let go of Ryoka, allowing the taller girl to breathe, and bent to shake paws with Mrsha. The Gnoll blinked up at Garia solemnly, and then licked

her lips as Garia held the door open.

“Come in! My family’s here and Fals came an hour ago. He’s really funny—but you knew that! There’s food ready and snacks—oh. Is uh, she coming?”

Garia had caught sight of Ivolethe. Like all people from this world, she stared a bit to the left of the faerie, looking at Ivolethe’s glamour. She looked apprehensive, no doubt remembering the events at the Runner’s Guild.

“Crap. I uh—”

Ryoka hesitated. She wanted to let Ivolethe come in, but she was well aware of the chaos the Frost Faerie could cause by herself. And it was dangerous for Ivolethe to be indoors as well, even invited. The iron in Garia’s home would be a problem.

For once, Ivolethe solved the problem by herself. She spoke loudly, making Garia jump. Apparently she could speak to whomever she pleased if the need arose, although she seldom bothered.

“I shall take my leave, Ryoka Griffin. I have things to see, and I don’t wish to listen to your mortal prattling all night.”

“Oh. Uh. Sorry.”

Garia stared at Ivolethe, white-faced. Ivolethe grinned at Ryoka and flicked her eyes inside calculatingly.

“However, if ye would leave food for me outside, I might consider blessing this place. A proper meal, though. Without iron, mind! And with lots of meat!”

“I’ll uh, I’ll do that.”

Wide-eyed, Garia watched as Ivolethe flew upwards and then disappeared rapidly into the sky. She looked at Ryoka. Ryoka shrugged.

“You heard her. Put something out after dinner. Lots of meat. I’ll bet her blessings are worth spit, but it’s better than having her annoyed. Don’t worry either way, though. She’s pretty harmless.”

Garia nodded uncertainly as Mrsha lost patience and padded into the house ahead of the two. Ryoka was about to follow when a snowball

spiraled down from above. It hit the back of her head and nearly knocked her flat.

Of course Ryoka had grown used to snowballs thrown by faeries before. She'd been hit by ones with rocks inside them, bits of ice, and so on. But this one had come down at an extreme speed and angle. It had a ton of force behind it. In short, it *hurt*. Ryoka stumbled, turned and raised her middle finger to the sky.

"Fuck you!"

A distant laugh answered her. That was coincidentally also when Fals and Garia's parents came out to meet Ryoka. Their first impression of her was thus an angry Asian girl flipping off the sky, hair covered with snow. As first impressions went...well, Ryoka had had worse.

"So you're friends with the Winter Sprites, Miss, ah, Ryoka?"

A few minutes later Ryoka was sitting around a table with Mrsha, Garia, Fals, and Mr. and Ms. Strongheart. Of course, no one spoke like that, so they were Wailant and Viceria, the married couple who'd raised Garia.

They...weren't what Ryoka had expected. For one thing, well, they didn't look the part. Not that Ryoka had expected a pair of Southern-accented people with hats and overalls, but she had considered the standards of farming in this world fairly below hers. She'd been prepared to meet a fairly poor couple, living in a village and farming a patch of land that might be owned by a [Lord] or other kind of landowner.

Instead, she met the oddest pair imaginable. The father, Wailant, had huge, tattooed and scarred arms revealed by his sleeveless cotton shirt. It had taken Ryoka several minutes just to process the incongruity of his appearance. She managed to break down the weirdness into several layers.

Firstly, his arms were muscled. Not surprising on a [Farmer], and Garia was certainly strong as all get-out from her years working. But the tattoos? One was of a twisting tentacle holding a ship, the other of some kind of

horrific fish with a gaping maw. The third, well, Ryoka was just glad that Mrsha was more interested in her food than in Wailant.

And his shirt! That was another weird part of him. Because despite wearing a sleeveless shirt, it was far from a poor quality cloth. The shirt itself was a light blue gilded with gold. It had a flowing edge around the bottom and sides reminiscent of a golden wave.

And the scars. Unless farming in this world involved fighting mutant rabbits with teeth like swords, Wailant had gotten the savage scars that covered his arms somewhere else. He had a particularly nasty circular wound—from an arrow, perhaps—on the side of his stubbled face.

In short, he looked as little like a [Farmer] as Ryoka could imagine. And his wife, Viceria?

She was a [Mage]. She wore the robe, spoke like Pisces when he wasn't being obnoxiously wordy, and Ryoka could sense the magic about her. She had long, flowing hair tied back in a braid—light brown, contrasting against Wailant's black hair. She was slim, elegant.

Ryoka sat at a dinner table with the two of Garia's parents as she ate, filling her plates with roast yams, a hot egg-and-pork casserole, spooned potatoes and some kind of weird, soft and sour vegetable called Tashal, and tried to make conversation.

"Uh, yes. That's right. Her name's Ivolethe. She's ah...a friend."

"Oh? I wasn't aware they had names. Garia told me about seeing your friend's true form. I had no idea they were using a glamour at the time, but that *would* explain their other abilities. How did you meet her?"

Viceria tapped her fingers together as she studied Ryoka over her plate. She was using silver...silverware. In fact, the plates were costly ceramics. Ryoka carefully chewed down a bite of Tashal—it really was good with potatoes, like sour cream—before replying.

"I ah, attracted their notice. Those little b—those pests followed me for days, pulling pranks on me, throwing snow at my head, and so on. In the end I managed to impress them a bit, and Ivolethe seemed to like me."

"So you have one of those devils following you?"

Sitting next to Fals and Viceria, Wailant snorted. He folded his arms as Mrsha tried to fill her mouth with food. The Gnoll was happily consuming everything she could reach, and her plate kept being filled by Wailant, who seemed to enjoy watching Mrsha eat. She and Garia were the only things he seemed to approve of—Fals and Ryoka were getting the third degree.

“Those pests can wreck a farm in a day. I remember one of the farmers south of here lost an entire spring harvest when they covered his fields with eight feet of snow! He had to hire [Diggers] to shift it while all the other snow had long melted away!”

Ryoka coughed awkwardly and saw Garia wince. Her friend was sitting on her right, next to Fals, and she looked guilty as her father stared hard at Ryoka.

“I uh, didn’t know about that. I’m sorry for your friend—”

“My friend? I hated that bastard. I’m glad the faeries covered his fields. Served him right. But your friend’s not going to do it to *my* farm now, is she?”

“No. Absolutely not. Ivolethe doesn’t generally cause trouble—she just pulls pranks.”

“But she can do quite a lot on her own, can’t she? Garia told us about what happened to the Runner’s Guild in Celum.”

Viceria gazed at Ryoka, making the Runner girl cough. She was saved by Fals, who interrupted with a placating smile.

“I’m sorry to say the Runner’s Guild—and most of the people within—probably deserved it in that case, Miss Viceria. I haven’t seen Ryoka’s little friend doing anything else like that. In fact, I’d consider someone who’s familiar with snow and such an asset.”

“Oh. So that’s why Miss Ryoka’s had all those lucrative contracts? I wanted to know how she got deliveries for gold—hundreds of gold coins or so Garia’s said—while she’s still running deliveries for silver and copper. Is it all because of your Frost Faerie friend?”

Garia sat up in her seat, flushing scarlet and glaring at her father.

“*Dad*. I don’t think Ryoka is—don’t embarrass me!”

Wailant Strongheart was unmoved. He was giving Ryoka a look she wished she could bottle and use on everyone she didn't like. Coming from him, it was, well, hard not to flinch. Ryoka met Wailant's green eyes, not backing down.

"I got those contracts because I was in the right place at the right time. I didn't take them from anyone."

"So you say."

Wailant shifted, uncrossing one arm. Ryoka could see every muscle in his right arm shift from the motion. Sitting across from her, Fals leaned back as one of Wailant's arms flexed, making the fish tattoo seem to swim. He grinned a bit desperately and nodded at Ryoka.

"We're ah, all City Runners here, Mister Wailant, Miss Viceria. No one takes advantage of each other if we can help it. We're a team. Ryoka just happens to be one of the best Runners in our Guild. In truth, I wouldn't take half the requests she does. Running through the High Passes? I'd rather play tag with a Creler, or paint myself red and run through the streets of Celum naked."

That got a laugh. Garia giggled and Wailant barked out a guffaw and slapped Fals on the back. Ryoka winced as she heard the *crack* of flesh on flesh. Fals kept grinning, although it looked like he was now struggling not to cry out in pain.

He was being charming, funny, and talkative. At first Ryoka had assumed it was the usual Fals, but she'd quickly realized that this was a defense tactic. Keeping Garia's parents entertained was far more preferable to having them ask piercing questions. Ryoka wondered how he'd survived an hour already.

To change the subject, Ryoka cast about the table. Hostile parents aside, Garia's house was really very nice. Extraordinarily nice. Again, Ryoka had expected a family that conformed to medieval economics, which was to say, dirt poor. But everything in the Strongheart family home looked well-made and some things looked expensive. They had a *bookshelf* filled with books for crying out loud! Ryoka chose that as the subject and nodded at it.

"I see you have quite a collection of books. I uh, didn't know that [Farmers] were so well read. I've tried buying books myself, but they're as

expensive as healing potions, some of them. How did you come by this collection?”

“We’re humble folk, Miss Ryoka. That doesn’t mean we’re stupid. Or poor, for that matter.”

How did she manage to put her foot further into her mouth? Ryoka saw Garia burying her head in her hands as Wailant pushed back his chair. There was nothing poor or humble about the way he brought out several of the books for Ryoka and Fals to admire. She stared at the covers, noting several from her time perusing Magnolia’s library.

“It’s a magnificent collection.”

“Of course it is! I’ve read them all. Viceria here knows several [Shopkeepers] and [Merchants] who sell to [Lords] and [Ladies]. Of course, a poor family of [Farmers] can’t afford more than one or two first-edition tomes. Read all of these, have you?”

“Not all of them.”

Ryoka found herself being quizzed aggressively on the books she *had* read as the dinner continued. All the while, she saw Garia grow more and more anxious. She kept breaking into her father’s flow, trying to change the subject.

“So uh, does anyone want dessert? Mrsha? Why don’t I uh, get it? And you, Dad.”

She practically dragged her father out of his chair and into the kitchen. Mrsha followed, waddling a bit with her full belly and standing upright so the food wouldn’t come out if she fell over. Fals took that moment to flee for the outhouse, leaving Ryoka in a moment’s reprieve.

Well, Viceria was still there. Ryoka eyed her across the table and saw the woman smile.

“I apologize for my husband, Miss Ryoka.”

“It’s uh, fine. Call me Ryoka. Why do I get the feeling that he doesn’t like me?”

Viceria laughed softly. She looked like she was ten years younger than she was, which was, according to Garia, in her thirties. Ryoka was having a

hard time imagining her giving birth to Garia. Oh, the features were there, the hair color was the same, but the body shape—no.

“I think that it’s because you look a lot like the girls that used to give Garia a hard time when she was growing up. You have their look, and I think Wailant’s concerned you might be taking advantage of Garia. I won’t pretend I didn’t have the same thoughts when I met young Fals, but he seems decent enough.”

That clarified some things. Ryoka sat back in her chair, hearing Garia’s not-so-quiet argument with her father about much the same subject in the kitchen.

“Oh? What do I look like?”

Viceria shrugged, looking slightly bitter.

“Tall, beautiful, thin. It’s not as if Garia doesn’t look lovely herself, but she thinks she should look more like me, when she inherited her father’s build. And of course, her first class was [Farmer], not [Mage]...”

“Wait, her class?”

Ryoka frowned. Viceria looked surprised.

“Of course. Don’t you know? Some classes dictate the way in which we, well, look. I am a [Mage], for instance. Working with magic means I tend to look younger than I really am—of course, there are spells that help as well. But [Mages] tend towards thinness. We burn too much energy for most of us to gain weight. Whereas classes like [Farmer], well, anyone who grows up with that class tends to grow a lot larger than say, someone who was raised as a [Clerk].”

Was that really true? Ryoka frowned as she tried to unpack this. The way you looked could tie to your class? She could buy the bit about [Mages] burning energy, but surely broad shoulders were in Garia’s genes, not a byproduct of her class. Then again, this was a world governed by Skills. Why couldn’t there be a passive effect that did just that?

“I didn’t know about classes like that. But Garia and I are, well, friends. She made my acquaintance and we’ve hung out. I wouldn’t ever take advantage of her. She’s a good person.”

“We know. But while she doesn’t say it, we’ve heard her talking about people less kind than you two are. We’ve met some of them before, as well.”

Viceria shook her head, looking troubled.

“Some girls seem to think they’re better than Garia just because they weigh less, or they can run faster. Apparently, Garia isn’t well thought of in the Runner’s Guild.”

The same in every world. Ryoka gritted her teeth. She took a breath, and then looked Viceria in the eye, speaking clearly.

“I think Garia’s worth twice as much as other City Runners. She’s had my back in two fights so far, and both times she didn’t hesitate to help me, even when we were fighting a group of adventurers.”

The woman blinked at her.

“Garia? In a fight?”

“*What?*”

There was an exclamation from the kitchen. Ryoka turned her head and saw Wailant, holding a pot full of custard. Behind him, Garia buried her face in her hands.

Wailant put the pot on the table and turned to face Ryoka. He wasn’t frowning, although he did loom a bit.

“Are you telling me my girl was in a fight?”

Ryoka leaned back a bit. This was going south. She wondered if she could jump out a window with Mrsha if it came to it.

“Yes, Mister Wailant. It was my fault. She was defending me after some idiots picked a fight and—”

“How’d she do?”

Wailant stared at Ryoka. She froze. He stared at her expectantly, as did Viceria.

“Did she knock anyone down? How many folks were in it? Did she kick anyone in the balls? I told her, that’s the way to start and end a fight in a hurry.”

“Dad!”

Ryoka stared at Wailant. She felt like she was running on the wrong track—she’d felt that way the instant she’d met Garia’s parents. But for the first time, she felt like she could see the right way to talk to him. So she sat up in her chair, smiled a bit, and nodded at Garia, who was red as an apple.

“One punch, Mister Wailant. She took out a Bronze-rank adventurer with one hit. She probably would have done the same to his friends, but the Watch broke things up before we could get to it.”

The fight at the inn with the adventurers that Persua had brought came out over dessert. Ryoka sat at the table, eating lightly spiced custard while Mrsha licked two bowls clean and then lapsed into a food coma. Fals came back, and Garia covered her burning face as her two parents heard both times when Garia had stepped up in a physical way to defend Ryoka.

The mood in the room had changed. Wailant was nodding with fierce, fatherly pride and Viceria was smiling as they heard how Garia had knocked out her opponents with one hit on both occasions.

“That’s my girl. One solid punch is all you need. Once the other fellow’s on the floor, a few good kicks and they’re out for good.”

He jabbed out with a fast punch to demonstrate, nearly clipping Fals. Ryoka grinned at him as Viceria filled her bowl with some more custard.

“You’re pretty proud of Garia for fighting. I would have thought you’d be worried.”

“Worried? Hah! Our daughter’s got [Enhanced Strength]! At her age, no less! She could knock out an ox with her fists if she wanted to.”

“Dad! Stop! Come on!”

“I don’t doubt she could. But Garia’s no fighter. She’s a [Runner].”

Wailant ignored his daughter as she tried to kick him underneath the table.

“Yes, but she’s *my* daughter, and that mean’s she’s got a warrior’s blood in her veins. She’s more than a match for a green-ass adventurer who doesn’t know the handle of his sword from the blade.”

Ryoka eyed Wailant, askance.

“I thought you were a [Farmer].”

He grinned at her, suddenly chummy.

“I am. But I used to fight for a living.”

“Really now?”

“Oh yes. I was a [Sailor]. Haven’t you seen the tattoos? I used to sail across the world, to all five continents!”

He flexed one bicep to show Ryoka the image of the tentacle grabbing the ship. She’d hardly missed it, but all the pieces suddenly fell into place. Well, some of them at least.

Fals blinked at Wailant.

“You were a [Sailor]? How’d you end up here?”

Wailant opened his mouth, but his wife cut in.

“My husband’s not a sailor, Fals. I’m sorry to say that’s the little lie he likes to tell. He did sail, but he was hardly an honest man.”

“Yeah, Dad. Tell the truth!”

Garia glared at Wailant, who protested.

“I was a [Sailor]!”

Two pairs of female eyes stared at him. He sighed.

“No? Fine. I was a [Pirate]. Happy?”

Both Ryoka and Fals’ mouths dropped open. Mrsha rolled over in her seat, oblivious, but suddenly Wailant the [Farmer] became someone else. He sat back in his chair, the custard forgotten and started telling the two Runners about his past.

“Oh yes, I was a [Pirate]. What, you think I got these scars from pulling up potatoes? Well, this one I got from killing a Creler. Nasty bastards—as bad as anything at sea, that’s the truth! But I took my first step on the deck. My family was from Baleros—yes, they were [Pirates] too. It’s in the blood, not that I knew them. My father died at sea before I was born and my mother died in a battle when I was five. I had two brothers and a sister—can’t tell you where they are. But I learned to fight and got my share of the plunder as soon as I could use a sword.”

The world was a funny place. Ryoka knew you could meet all kinds of people in her world, people who lived in quiet places who had all kinds of amazing stories to tell. But this? Wailant had been a [Pirate]. He'd sailed under a ruthless [Pirate Captain], taken down enemy ships, fought in the worst storms against monsters, even battled with a group of Gold-rank adventurers who'd been after his ship!

He'd been a Level 27 [Pirate] when he quit sailing for good and found an honest ship headed for Izril. Not because he'd lost his ship or run into any bad luck either—he'd retired as wealthy as any Gold-rank adventurer. But he hadn't stayed at sea like the rest of his crew.

"I got sick of rocking ships, the damp, salt in my hair and thousands of glowing eyes watching me from the waters on bad nights. Out there in the depths of the sea...I could have become a [Storm Sailor], or a [Captain] of my own ship had I wanted to. But I chose land instead. Do I have regrets? Perhaps. I could have had a ship of my own, but you see, I knew in my heart that I was making the right choice..."

Both Garia and her mother rolled their eyes as Wailant went on. They'd heard this story a thousand times, probably inflated no end over the years. But Ryoka and Fals were entranced. Fals broke in as Wailant waxed poetical about nights spent on deck, staring up at the stars.

"How'd you end up around here though, so far from the sea?"

The man grimaced.

"Practicality. The vast amount of my fortune went to clearing the bounty on my head. What I had left I used to buy a farm, and then to pay for food and supplies for the first few years before I leveled up enough to make a living with my own hands. I bought it far inland because I was sick of seeing water—and because I had more than a few enemies who would like to see me dead. I thought a farm would be nice and relaxing—and it was, after I learned how to manage it!"

The first few years had not been kind to Wailant, but he'd persevered, not shying from the work.

"Plus, I had my advantages. I couldn't figure out how to make the damn oxen plough a straight line for months, but I didn't have to stick together in

a village, afraid of monsters at night. If a band of Goblins came roaming around, or a Creler tried to dig a nest in my lands, I'd kill it with this!"

He had a cutlass, shimmering with an enchantment that he apparently kept with him while farming at all times. He'd looted it as his share of treasure long ago, and it had saved his life more than once on the farm.

"It's also how I met Viceria. She was a Wistram graduate, trying to study the Blood Fields when she ran into a group of Carn Wolves. I found her escort dead and killed two of the damn things before the pack ran off. She and I got to talking, and well, nights are cold on a farm."

"Ew! *Dad!*"

Garia shoved her father, sending him tumbling across the room. He cursed like a sailor—or pirate—as he got to his feet, and Ryoka sat back in her chair. That explained...a lot.

"That's incredible. And you—Miss Viceria—"

"Just call me Viceria. That's right. I stayed. I'm an expert at magic involving plants. I'm no [Geomancer], but rather a [Green Mage]. That's different from a [Druid], by the way. I'm a respectable level in that, but I found being a [Farmer] far easier than competing at Wistram. There's not much respect for disciplines involving growing, or there wasn't when I lived there."

And so, the incredible farming duo had been born. Neither Wailant nor Viceria were specialists in the [Farmer] class like the Level 30 [Farmers] who could supply an entire city with produce, but they had their own skillsets that helped a great deal.

"Most farms, well, they need two dozen farmhands just to harvest and guards and so on. Even a high-level [Farmer] has to be wary of bandits and monsters. I don't have that issue, and my wife has the spells to grow crops faster than normal, as good as a Skill! Between the two of us, we supply a good deal of produce for Celum. Enough to live comfortably on and I can always hire a few brats to take in the harvest when it comes time for it. Besides, the farming life's fairly quiet, and I enjoy not fighting for my life every other day."

Wailant and Viceria smiled as they looked at each other. Garia looked away, blushing, but Ryoka felt a bit envious. Wailant had seen the kraken—literally, apparently—and walked away. He'd found a way to live that was satisfying and he'd found someone to share it with.

She took a sip of mulled wine. By this point, everyone was sitting around a dim fire. Mrsha was curled up next to it, snoring, and Garia was yawning. As Fals and Ryoka chatted to her parents, Garia grew sleepier, until she had to excuse herself for the night.

"I might have to do the same."

Fals admitted after a jaw-cracking yawn. He stood up as Viceria offered to show him to the room they'd prepared for him. She, Garia, and Fals left as Wailant sat by Ryoka, staring at the fire. Viceria came back alone, and that left Ryoka with the two older Stronghearts.

She didn't mind. It was odd, but in the course of an evening, Wailant and Viceria had turned from intimidating, antagonistic parents into, well, people. Ryoka even found herself liking Wailant's style of dressing. Apparently he couldn't live with sleeves after having bared arms all his life.

"It's an incredible place you have here, Wailant, Viceria. I'm glad Garia's got such great parents."

"Hah. Great parents would be able to help their daughter. But she's a [Runner] and we've no idea if she's safe or in danger half the time. It's only when she comes back that we know she's safe, and she does that too seldom."

Wailant sat with a stiff drink in his hand. He'd already downed six, having an incredibly high tolerance for alcohol, but he was in the depressed stage. Viceria sat with wine by the fire, glancing between it and at Ryoka.

"She says she's been doing well. But I've heard her stories and I hear you have something to do with helping her out."

"Just a few things here and there. Nothing much."

Ryoka shook her head. Wailant stared at her, tapping his fingers.

"That's not what she says. She came back with potions at her belt a few weeks ago. That was thanks to you. We offered her coin for it before, but she's too proud—"

“She won’t let us buy her magical artifacts, or buy her things ourselves.”

That surprised Ryoka. She would have thought Garia would have taken any chance to get ahead, but her parents shook their heads when asked.

“My daughter’s as stubborn as I am. She wanted to fit in, not get ahead. I told her the best Runners have all the advantages they can get, but she thought it would make her too different, that it was *cheating*. I told her, on the sea you cheat if you can do it! Put a hole in the enemy’s hull, climb onto their decks and stab them while they’re sleeping! But Garia’s not like me.”

“She’s not a warrior, you mean?”

Wailant shook his head, looking unhappy.

“I’d have liked her to be. It needn’t be her class, but it would set my mind at ease if she could defend herself. Only, she’s got no talent with a sword.”

“Or magic.”

Viceria nodded as she traced around the rim of her cup.

“She can’t use a spear—”

“Or bow—”

“And I wouldn’t bet a Drowned Man’s eye against her hitting anything but a tree with a hatchet. Our daughter’s strong and tough, but she’s too clumsy to be a warrior, if she had the temperament for that class to begin with. Which she doesn’t.”

Wailant downed his cup, tossed it aside. Viceria gave him an accusing look which he ignored. He stared at Ryoka.

“You say she punched out a man in armor? That’s good. But fists aren’t enough against swords or arrows, let alone magic. A brawl’s one thing, but [Bandits]? How can I rest easy knowing she might be jumped by them? Sea’s wrath, she *has* been attacked before. Someday I’ll get a letter from the Runner’s Guild, and then...”

He trailed off, looking tired and worried. In that moment, he looked like every parent Ryoka had ever known. Like her parents. She felt something squeeze at her heart.

“Garia’s brave. She has people looking out for her. Fals, for instance, and I try when I’m in the area. If fighting’s the problem, maybe she can carry artifacts?”

“Maybe. But an artifact’s only good if you can use it. A Skill lasts, and there’s the instinct of a warrior as well. I could be sure of myself if I was jumped, but if someone took her by surprise—salt and shores, I’m not half as strong as I would be on a ship, but I wish I could give that to Garia. Some way to dodge arrows. Or a ring! But that costs coin and the farm doesn’t earn enough for us to buy an artifact that expensive...”

Ryoka stared at the fire. A girl who couldn’t fight and two parents who worried about her. It was a story for this world. In any other world, Garia could live while relying on law enforcement, but here the law ended at the gates, and sometimes didn’t even work within a city. What could you give someone who couldn’t use a sword? Without the ability to use magic?

The Runner girl stared at Wailant’s arm, and then at her hand. She made a fist, and stared at it.

“Oh.”

Both Wailant and Viceria looked at Ryoka. She blinked at her hand. It felt like forever since she’d...she stood up and threw a punch.

“Nice one.”

Wailant watched Ryoka as she punched and then threw a hook. She stood differently, moved differently than Wailant as she did. He’d punched like a boxer, but Ryoka kept her hands higher, at head-level, and further apart, bouncing on her feet. She was moving according to a style, and Wailant, used to fighting, saw it.

“Are you a [Fistfighter], or some kind of [Brawler]?”

“Not quite. I learned how to fight back home. Only, it’s not a Skill I learned, but a style. A way of fighting.”

Ryoka jumped and kicked. Viceria made a sound. Wailant stared.

“I’ve seen idiots do that when fighting. Jumping around before they get cut to ribbons. But that looked like it could have done damage.”

“Not to a monster. Not with my strength.”

Ryoka shook her head, remembering trying to fight a Carn Wolf. She punched and kicked, dodging back from an imaginary foe. Her muscles protested a bit. How long had it been since Ryoka had *practiced*?

“So why learn how to fight like that?”

“It helps. Against humans, people with knives. I could defend myself. But I’m not strong enough. If I throw a punch, it won’t knock down a Carn Wolf. Or a Minotaur.”

She paused, felt a pang and hung her head. Calruz. Wailant nodded.

“Minotaurs can’t be beat with bare hands. I’ve seen their black ships too many times. They’re deadly at sea and on land. No sane [Pirate] goes near their islands. But learning to fight like that...there’s some grace to it. Better than I do in a fight at a bar.”

“Yeah. Only it won’t save me from a monster attack. That’s what my legs are for.”

Ryoka turned to Wailant and Viceria. She tapped her arm.

“I’m not strong enough, like I said. If I punch with my...style, I can be sure I’ll hit someone. However, even with a good punch it won’t do enough. Not from me. But if someone else punched like that, someone who could knock an ox out with a punch...”

The former [Pirate] and [Green Mage] stared at Ryoka. Wailant sat up. Viceria smiled.

“You think Garia could learn to fight with her fists? She’s never learnt any other way of fighting. She doesn’t have the knack for it.”

“Yeah, well, martial arts isn’t just about talent. It’s something everyone can learn. It just takes practice.”

“Martial arts. Is that what it’s called?”

Ryoka shook her head, smiling.

“No. This is called Muay Thai Kickboxing. And this—”

She took a different stance, threw a different punch.

“—is called Karate. It might be better for Garia. I don’t know. I thought about teaching some techniques when I saw her in that fight at the inn. I

never got around to it. But if you're worried, I could give her some lessons. She could practice herself if she takes to it."

She looked at Wailant and Viceria. It was just a thought, something to reassure them. The two parents looked at each other, speaking without words and then Wailant stood up. He cracked his neck, and then beckoned at Ryoka.

"Try me, then. Go ahead. I've a few drinks, but if you can knock me down...you don't have a class, do you?"

She grinned at him.

"Not a one."

"Garia said that. I couldn't believe someone would be that stupid."

"Really? Then let me show you—"

Ryoka twisted, kicked. Wailant dodged back. He laughed, surprised, as Ryoka hopped backwards. She grinned at him, beckoned.

There was something here. In this room, as Viceria told them to not damage the furniture and Ryoka tagged Wailant with a kick that sobered him up and he showed her how fast a former [Pirate] could punch.

In the end, they stopped with bruises and light hearts. Ryoka found herself being slapped on the back by Wailant, and talking with Viceria. She smiled, and carried Mrsha to a room upstairs to sleep. She thought, just for an instant, that it was strange. She'd expected awkwardness, dreaded meeting Garia's parents, and gotten off to the worst start possible. But suddenly—

She was enjoying herself.

Fancy that. Then Ryoka slept. The next day, she began teaching Garia how to punch. And Ivolethe—

Began teaching her how to use magic.

Ryoka Griffin stood on a hill, facing the wind. She breathed in deeply, and felt the chill of the morning's air blow through her hair. She stared into the open sky and felt the world pressing down at her.

The clouds were impossibly high overhead. The wind rushed about her, invigorating Ryoka, filling her with quiet contemplation. Her breathing slowed. Her pulse settled. She cleared her mind, became still, meditative. Her mind grew tranquil as Ryoka absorbed nature—

“Not like *that*, fool! What are ye doing?”

Someone threw snow into Ryoka's face. She spluttered, opened her eyes, and scowled at Ivolethe.

“What the hell was that for? I'm trying to sense the wind!”

Ivolethe buzzed around Ryoka's head, an angry blue butterfly with attitude.

“What kind of an idiot does that with their eyes closed? I told ye, to learn faerie magic, ye must first sense the wind.”

“Right. And that's *all* you said. I'm here for a lesson. So tell me, how do I sense the wind?”

Ryoka folded her arms and scowled. Ivolethe looked exasperated.

The two were standing on a snowy hilltop near the Strongheart farm. Ryoka had woken up to a very enjoyable breakfast, talked with Garia about learning martial arts and gotten the girl's wary agreement. She'd taught the girl how to stand and punch and Garia had seemed willing to give it a try, even though she'd giggled and not taken it as seriously as Ryoka would have liked. But Fals had tried it as well, and that had made Garia grow more focused.

Everything had been going swimmingly, in short, until Ivolethe appeared and demanded that Ryoka start learning faerie magic. And that too

was great—in fact, Ryoka was excited by the prospect.

Only it appeared Ivolethe's methods of teaching weren't as straightforward as Ryoka's. She'd taken Ryoka to this hill and told her to sense the wind.

“How does it work?”

Ivolethe sighed gustily. She flew in front of Ryoka, folding her tiny pale-blue transparent arms and pointed.

“Ye see the wind?”

“Uh, maybe. I see air.”

Ryoka stared at a blank patch the faerie was pointing at, which was probably what Ivolethe meant. Ivolethe smiled.

“Good! Now follow it.”

She waited. Ryoka stared at the empty patch of air and then glanced at Ivolethe.

“What do you mean, ‘follow it’? There's nothing to see!”

Ivolethe slapped a hand to her face, making a sound like breaking icicles. She flew to Ryoka's face and punched the girl in the eye. Ryoka shouted and swung wildly.

“Did I tell ye to *stop* looking? Look at the wind, you bleeding idiot!”

“There's nothing to see!”

“*Exactly!* So look at nothing and see where it goes!”

Ivolethe screamed in Ryoka's ear. Ryoka opened her watering eye and glared at the faerie. The faerie glared back.

"Let me get this straight. You're telling me to stare at something invisible."

Ivolethe rolled her eyes.

"Of *course*. To control the wind, to know it, ye must see it. And it is invisible! Of course it is! Otherwise you mortals would have already seen it!"

"But how can I see if—"

Ryoka guarded her face as Ivolethe swooped at her again. The faerie flew past her and spoke into her ear.

"*Look*, fool. Look at what is invisible and see it. With your eyes. With your soul. Look and see. That is all I need tell you. Look. Ye have done it once, on the magic coach."

Ryoka remembered. She'd seen Ivolethe flying, and seen the wind, followed it for one glorious second. She didn't remember *how* she'd done it, but...she nodded.

"Fine. I'll try."

Ivolethe nodded, still looking impatient. Ryoka took a deep breath and stared ahead. Watch the wind. See it.

She saw nothing. The wind blew, and it went still. It blew again, but aside from some snow caught up by it, there was nothing to see. Nothing to look at. Ryoka struggled to look at the wind, but she *always* looked at the wind, didn't she? It was always there.

Invisible. Unseen. How was she supposed to see it? Ryoka tried adjusting the way she looked at the world, focusing her eyes, tracing an

imaginary path the wind took. Nothing worked.

Five minutes passed. Ryoka searched the air for something she couldn't see, couldn't imagine seeing, and Ivolethe floated in the air beside her, making discontented faces. She yawned hugely, and Ryoka gritted her teeth.

"I saw that."

"Did ye? Good. Your eyes are working, then. Now see *this*."

Ivolethe yawned wider, showing Ryoka the inside of her mouth, pale red ice and sharp teeth. She flipped one wing as Ryoka growled to herself.

"Hurry up! I'm bored!"

"I'm trying to *learn*. You're supposed to be my teacher! Shouldn't you have some patience and let me try to figure this out?"

"No, fool! Because if ye were going to get it, you'd have already gotten it by now! Magic isn't something you can keep trying over and over!"

"That's because you're not giving me any instructions. If you want me to see the wind, tell me how in more detail."

Ryoka snapped, but Ivolethe just flipped herself over so she was staring at Ryoka upside down. She spoke, suddenly serious.

"I cannot."

"Why not? Because it's secret?"

“No, because there are no words for it. It is *magic*, Ryoka Griffin. Magic. It is something you understand in here, not here.”

She flew over and tapped Ryoka’s chest, then flew up and tapped her head. Ryoka nodded slowly.

“Instinct? I have to get a feel for it, that’s what you’re saying. Then if I keep practicing—”

“No.”

Ivolethe sighed. She rubbed at her face, frowning hard. She shook her head.

“It is not instinct. You cannot learn this by practicing.”

“But you said—”

“It is grace, mortal. Grace and naught else. Grace and wonder. A moment. It is not something ye can learn in a book. It is not something you can keep trying to do. You will learn it in a moment of purest understanding—or never.”

The Frost Faerie looked at Ryoka in the eye. Ryoka felt a slight chill that had nothing to do with the cold. She opened her mouth, paused. What Ivolethe said spoke to her, but it made no sense at the same time.

“That’s not how magic works in this world, though. [Mages] study magic in books. They can write it down. They *have* to study.”

“True.”

Ivolethe nodded, frowning.

“How shall I explain? That is magic. Tamed, and bent for use, yes, but it is still magic. But it is not *my* magic. Not the magic of the fae. Not deep magic, which runs wild. If ye wish to study that magic, practice. Understand, by all means. But ye shall never see the wind if you think of it as something to be understood, to be learned. The wind is the wind. I ask you to see it, Ryoka. Not understand the *why* of it.”

Ryoka struggled to make sense of this. On one level she got what Ivolethe was saying. On another...how could you stare at something and not want to know *why* it was? But that was magic. Ivolethe's magic.

A moment of grace.

“Back to trying. Try and if you cannot see it, we shall try later. But this is the first step, Ryoka. The only step. Learn to do this, and ye shall see all in time.”

See the wind. Ryoka tried. She really did. But she couldn't keep what Ivolethe had said in her mind and just try to feel something naturally. And the Frost Faerie saw it.

“Stop. Another chance will come. Look for the wind elsewhere, Ryoka, but ye won't see it here.”

And that was it. The lesson was done. Ivolethe floated past Ryoka as the girl sighed, disappointed. The Frost Faerie laughed as she pointed down the hill.

“Go back to your mortal friends. Look at the child!”

Ryoka turned and saw that her martial arts lesson had attracted more than just Fals. Mrsha was standing clumsily in the snow, trying to punch like Garia. She kept punching, and falling over by her own momentum.

It was very cute. Ryoka laughed and took out her iPhone as she descended the hill. She tried to turn it on, but found to her deepest disappointment that it had run out of power! She cursed to herself. It was hard to remember to get Pisces to cast [Repair] on it. Erin would just have to imagine Mrsha's antics.

"Ryoka! I don't think this is right!"

Garia was complaining as she punched the air, blushing as Fals did the same beside her. She'd been willing to try learning, especially after her father had vouched for the effectiveness of Ryoka's kick, but she was clearly feeling silly.

"Don't worry, you're doing good. Raise your arm a bit more. And like I said—each time you punch, breathe out. Like this."

Ryoka demonstrated, bringing her fists up and punching slowly as she exhaled. Garia copied her, but complained immediately afterwards.

"I get that I'm learning to punch, but I feel silly. I'm just hitting the air!"

"Well, that's the point. Look, you're practicing, like you would with a sword."

"Yeah, but—no one's going to stand there and let me punch them."

The girl rolled her eyes and Ryoka barely resisted doing the same.

"I know that, but you have to start at the beginning. Look, just punch like I showed you. You're using the muscles in your stomach. If you can feel them as you punch..."

"But why would muscles in my stomach help my arms?"

Garia looked confused. Ryoka groaned. How could you explain hundreds of years of biological science to someone who hadn't even heard of muscle fibers? Well, with martial arts, actually.

“It’s all connected. Look, one of the principle of martial arts is connectedness. Every part of the body works together. Your arms aren’t one separate thing. That’s why when you punch, your entire body, from your arms to your legs go into one motion. That’s why you take a stance and move the same way. It’s the most effective.”

“Is that why you had me do jumping jacks?”

“That’s part of the warm up, yes. So is swinging your arms, rolling your hips, and everything else. You need to be flexible. That’s what these exercises will help you do as well—build muscle so you can move freely.”

“I don’t see why. My arms are already strong. Isn’t that enough if I’m punching someone?”

Garia’s cheeks were red as Ryoka walked her through more exercises, making her learn how to do knee lifts to the elbow, and then *hiza-geri*, a form of knee striking from Shotokan Karate. She clearly didn’t want Fals to see her doing this silly routine, for all he was doing it with the two girls and Mrsha was too.

“Punching someone isn’t enough, Garia. Strength isn’t enough, although it’s pretty damn important. But martial arts practices defense, movement—it’s a way of living. It’s...a way to be graceful. Grace.”

Ryoka stared ahead until she realized she’d stopped doing knee strikes. She made Garia do twenty until the girl complained her legs were getting tired.

“And I have to do this every day?”

“If you want to get good, yes.”

Ryoka snapped, growing impatient with Garia. She was trying to help, but Garia seemed determined not to get through even the basic forms! She was trying to help—

“Why don’t you show us what a master looks like, Ryoka? I’m sure you see how all this matters, but I’m like Garia. It feels silly to do all this. What does it look like once you keep practicing for a while?”

Fals spoke up and Ryoka blinked at him. She opened her mouth to tell him it wasn’t one kind of thing—and then realized he was right.

Mrsha had grown bored of watching Ryoka practice with Garia. She'd started playing in the snow. Garia's parents had a hot drink and were smiling and Garia looked fed up. Ivolethe was laughing at Ryoka, and Fals had his eyebrows raised.

They *didn't* know what martial arts looked like. Perhaps no one in this world did. Ryoka nodded.

"You're right, Fals. Let me show you what it looks like, Garia, everyone. Mrsha, get back. Ivolethe, you can stay right there for all I care. I'll show you...what training your body can do."

Ryoka took a few steps away from Garia and cleared some snow off of the ground. There was grass underfoot. Not ideal—Ryoka would have liked a firmer surface, but it would have to do.

Garia sat back with Fals, blushing at him and watching Ryoka with a bit of interest. Ryoka smiled to herself. There was something familiar about this moment. Hadn't she done this once? Oh yes. When her leg had been healed. When she'd been able to move again.

It was the same. Ryoka took a breath, and then ran forwards. She jumped, and then did a handspring into the air. Her audience *gasped*, but that was only a warm-up. Ryoka landed, twisted, and backflipped up and over, landing on a patch of snow to silence, and then cheering.

"What was *that*? How did you do *that*?"

Garia nearly tripped over her own feet, running over to Ryoka. She stared in amazement at the girl, but Ryoka put up a hand.

"I'm just getting started. Watch out—"

She did a standing front flip, which was easy, but again, totally astounded everyone watching. Mrsha ran over to Ryoka, screaming in inaudible excitement. Fals stared at his feet and hopped experimentally as if to try.

The Humans and Gnoll watched as Ryoka did another backflip, this time with a run up. Ryoka cursed as she nearly slipped on landing. The snow was *not* the place for tricks. But her audience didn't care. They had never seen someone *move* like Ryoka could.

The next thing Ryoka tried was a standing cork, or standing corkscrew. It involved her standing with her left leg raised slightly off the ground and behind her right leg, which was slightly bent. Then, Ryoka jumped up and her entire body *twisted* around and up, sending her spinning up and around. It wasn't like a front flip at all. In fact, it was so fast that Garia and the others couldn't even tell what Ryoka had done.

It was a move from a martial art devoted just to tricks. Appropriately, it was called Tricking, a way of doing flashy moves like you'd see in movies. Naturally, Ryoka had learned how to do several tricks, and this one, a standing cork seemed to defy the laws of gravity for those watching it for the first time.

In slow motion, it would look as if Ryoka's leg came up, propelling her into the air, and then her body curled and twisted several times before her foot came down, landing her on the ground. Ryoka did this again for her stunned audience—

And wiped out.

Spectacularly, as it happened. Ryoka messed up the landing and slipped on some snow and hit the ground *hard*. She was up in a second to reassure Mrsha, but she'd hit herself hard enough to bruise.

That actually helped, because after seeing her flub so badly, the watchers were even more convinced Ryoka was insane as she did several more tricks. Determined to make up for that hilarious failure, Ryoka did a spinning aerial kick that hit Ivolethe as the faerie flew a good six feet up in the air. The faerie went flying, screaming insults, more surprised than hurt.

"How are you doing that?"

"Practice!"

Ryoka laughed as she did a series of tricks, spinning and kicking into the air, flipping around—flying. Tricking. It wasn't a formal martial art. Or rather, it wasn't a type of martial arts that applied to fighting or self-defense. It was more like a sport, an activity, an exhibition of what the human body could *do*.

There were very few situations that required Ryoka to jump into the air, spin, land on one leg, flip herself forward and *then* kick, but that wasn't the

point.

It was a performance. Ryoka did a running flip off of a handstand in the snow, jumped up, kicked at a target twice her height in the air and landed. She nearly slipped and fell in the snow, but then she was laughing, hearing Garia and Fals shout in amazement.

“See? This is martial arts! This is what you can do if you *practice!*”

Next, Ryoka showed the group some more practical moves, doing the roundhouse kick she loved so much, punching, blocking, moving to avoid and counter invisible enemies. It wasn’t as showy as Tricking, but it was just as amazing to the people watching.

Because they had never seen this either. Warriors with swords were one thing, but this was different. This was martial *arts*, which emphasized moves that had no wasted movement, that could be performed because the user had practiced them again and again.

No one in this world did flips. What would be the point? Oh, maybe a [Tumbler] could do it, or an [Acrobat] if they even existed. But no one in this world had had the time to practice, to do a backflip. Because there was no point! No point, which is why there weren’t people doing acrobatic tricks in ancient Rome, at least, as far as Ryoka knew.

There was no necessity to anything Ryoka did. No reason to do it, except because it was amazing and wonderful and inspiring.

And fun.

And as Ryoka ran and did a handspring into the air, she felt alive. She’d forgotten, somewhere, what it was like to just *move* for the sake of moving. The wind was blowing through her hair. She felt like she was flying, just like the first time she’d ever pulled one of these tricks off.

It felt as though at any moment, as you were flying upwards, the world twisting around you, that you could just soar into the heavens, that your body could carry you upwards without limit. Ryoka leapt, and saw something in the air.

A flash of movement. She saw the wind. She saw it twist around her—

“*Ryoka!*”

Garia cried out and Ryoka found herself flipping over and over, upwards and up. And then down. She shouted, lost control—

And fell.

It was a long way down. When Ryoka woke up with Mrsha covering her face, Garia told her Ryoka had gone for a gainer, a backflip off of one foot. She'd leapt into the air, and then, somehow, kept flipping upwards. She ended up flying ten feet into the air before falling. Ryoka had successfully done a quadruple gainer, a feat never performed in the history of human kind as something—the wind—had carried her up.

Unfortunately, she'd missed the landing. Panicked, confused by what had happened, Ryoka had landed the most impressive face-plant in the snow, again, perhaps the most impressive one ever seen. She'd knocked herself out as everyone had gone running over.

When she'd heard all of this and gotten Mrsha off her, Ryoka sat up, looked for Ivolethe, and tried to kill her friend.

"What the hell was *that* for? Was that payback for kicking you? Because if it was—"

"It wasn't me! It *wasn't me!*"

Ivolethe shouted as she flew away from Ryoka. The girl stopped, glaring at Ivolethe and swaying on her feet.

"What the hell do you mean? It *was* you! I saw it! You used the wind —"

"Not me, you fool! I did nothing!"

"What?"

Ryoka stared at her. She realized what Ivolethe was saying and paled.

"But then I—"

The Frost Faerie grinned at Ryoka. The girl froze, staring at her, at the clear blue sky.

“But that’s impossible. I was showing off. I wasn’t trying to—”

Ivolethe floated up, smiling broadly. She tapped Ryoka in the chest, grinning and shaking her head.

“Showing off? That was the best time for it! You didn’t try. In that moment, ye were Ryoka at your most natural. You did not feel. You saw. And the wind saw *you*.”

“I did it?”

Ryoka stared at Ivolethe. She stared around, at where Fals was gingerly trying to do a handstand, at Garia, who was determinedly punching the air and Mrsha, doing flips as Wailant tossed her up and Viceria watched with a wand at the ready, just in case.

Then she looked at Ivolethe. To her surprise, there were tears in the faerie’s eyes.

“What’s wrong?”

The small Frost Faerie shook her head.

“Ah. I did not know. I did not know what else Humans came up with. I lived with a body like yours for years, but this?”

She did a corkscrew in the air, flipping over, a perfect copy of the move Ryoka had done. Ivolethe laughed.

“This! This is new. This is something else. And for this, Ryoka Griffin, I thank you. For showing me something I have never seen.”

She landed on the ground, and took a few steps. Ivolethe kicked up into the air and backflipped up past Ryoka, into the sky. Her laughter was all Ryoka heard. It filled the world as Ivolethe flipped upwards, not flying, but borne by the wind. Ryoka stared as the faerie flew and whispered one word.

“Grace.”

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1.02 D

It was a hot, humid day when Quallet Marshhand walked into the recruiting grounds and claimed the half-rotted booth he'd bought for the day. It was *always* a hot day in Baleros. At least the winter kept the worst edge of the heat off, but Quallet had gotten used to feeling sweat run down his face long ago.

The booth Quallet had bought for five silver pieces wasn't worth half a copper one, in his opinion. The humid weather had already rotted half of the woodwork, and he was sure that if he put his axe or helmet on the booth, it would collapse. And scrabbling around in the dirt for his gear wouldn't do him any favors, especially when he was on a tight schedule.

So Quallet leaned his axe against the booth and kept his helmet on. It was already hot, and at least the helmet added to his presence. He had to compete with the others standing at their respective booths and shouting. It wasn't like this recruiting ground was particularly large; there were only six or so occupied booths, but the recruiters standing at each one were shouting loud enough for twice their number.

"Any [Mages] are welcome to the Tanglelurk Lights!"

"Roll up and become one of the Virulent Plague! Enlist with a friend and earn double pay for your first month!"

"Join the Raverian Fighters! We're offering a premium on experienced warriors! Apply now!"

Quallet had to smirk when he heard the last shout. The Raverian Fighters? They must be desperate to be recruiting in the middle of a campaign. Anyone with half a brain would know better than to join that company, especially with how things were going.

Still, mocking the opposition was a pointless endeavor. Quallet was here to recruit, so he drew in a breath and began shouting himself.

"Gravetender's Fist is accepting new recruits! Join an experienced suppression company and make coin *without* dying in your first battle!"

Heads turned and instantly, a fair number of the individuals in the recruiting grounds began drifting over in his direction. Quallet let them come, not bothering to redouble his shouting. Instead he stood, arms crossed, waiting.

It was about presence. In Baleros, a company of warriors might live or die based on the efforts of their recruiters. These groups or individuals would go from village to city, sometimes competing against hundreds of other companies to find talent, other times marching through an empty dirt street and shouting by themselves.

It was hard, unrewarding work, and usually given to an unlucky officer or as punishment detail. You'd never see one of the leaders of the Four Great Companies come to this recruiting ground. No, you'd get some unhappy [Sergeant], trying to meet his quota and stay out of the heat.

And that was the mistake most companies made. Because a company was only as good as its recruits, and Quallet had learned long ago that the best recruits were snapped up in an instant. Hence, why he'd come himself.

He was a Level 32 [Mercenary Captain], a seasoned warrior and a powerful leader in his own right. Quallet knew at a glance that he was the highest-leveled individual in the entire recruiting ground, and he had the armor and flash to go along with his Skills.

Thus, the large group of Humans, Lizardfolk, Dullahans and the smaller handful of Centaurs drew closer to see what he was offering. In Baleros, the mercenary companies that fought and bled and died for every petty squabble and major war came in every flavor and kind imaginable. New and experienced soldiers would frequent these grounds, seeking out the best contracts for themselves.

Not that this backwater village had any experienced warriors. It had probably been visited at the start of winter. Now, only unseasoned raw recruits were left, people with no combat classes that probably had never held a sword. Not ideal for company recruiting, but fine with Quallet. Scooping up a hundred such people was his goal today. It would allow him to sell his services in the nearest warzone for quite a bit of gold.

The trick was that he represented a company by himself. As a [Mercenary Captain], Quallet had the Skills to turn the worst fighters into a

half-decent force, with him leading them. With a hundred or so fresh recruits, Quallet could advertise his company to the highest bidder at a competitive rate. Just so long as Quallet found a decent pool of people to draw from, and made sure that the best of the bunch weren't snapped up.

He had an advantage there too. Among the precious Skills that allowed him to lead his company, Quallet had the Skill [Talent Seeker], which allowed him to find the best of any bunch for his company. Assuming the other recruiters didn't have similar abilities—and it was a good bet this lot were only [Sergeants] and [Soldiers] with few Skills between them—Quallet would walk away with most of his company within the hour.

A decent crowd had gathered—quite a lot of Humans for a village Quallet could have sworn was filled with Lizardfolk. No matter. Him being Human helped in that area as well. He took a breath and spoke at a field roar, making the people closest to him flinch back.

“So you're in need of coin, eh? Fancy going to war? Running from something, or seeking adventure? You're in the right place. A [Soldier] lives to fight, and you'll see plenty of that in Baleros, where the jungles run red with blood!”

That drew knowing nods from several in the crowd, but the Humans just stared at him. They were an odd bunch, dressed strangely with bright clothing. One had a strange, flat object with a glowing light coming out one end. Some kind of artifact? Quallet pretended not to notice. He went on with his little speech, going through the same motions like he had a thousand times.

“Don't fancy being a [Soldier]? A [Warrior] will find just as much work, and the best can earn a living as an adventurer. Joining up with a company is the right first step. However, what these other companies don't tell you is that of every ten raw recruits that enlist, six of them will be dead in the first year!”

That rattled his audience. Quallet looked among them. Yes, a group of young Lizardfolk, scales practically fresh. Dullahans with wood armor, all young, most carrying their heads and peering at him uncertainly. The Centaurs shifted from foot to foot and the Humans—still staring.

The other recruiters in the square were now giving Quallet death-glances from where they stood, but he didn't care. He spoke the truth and every recruiter knew it. But only Quallet could turn that knowledge into an asset.

"Four in ten odds don't sound good to you lot, eh? It takes a steady hand and talent to survive your first clash. Fancy yourselves natural-born fighters? You, boy."

He pointed at a pale-skinned youth wearing some sort of hat. It looked like nothing Quallet had ever seen before. The material was bright and there was some kind of symbol on top. A company's crest? A red bird sitting on an odd bit of wood stared at him over the word... 'Cardinals'?

Never mind. Quallet stared as the young man looked around and then grinned nervously.

"What, me?"

"Yes, you! Ever been in combat? Ever killed an opponent? You look sturdy enough. Good with a sword, are you?"

The young man stiffened. He hadn't, Quallet knew, been in any fights to the death before. He didn't have the look. And he wasn't armed. Come to that, none of the Humans were. But bravado was one of the key aspects of youth, so the young man with the odd hat grinned as his Human friends laughed.

"Not with a *sword*, but...I've been in a few fights!"

It took all of Quallet's willpower not to grimace at the stupid boast. A few fights? He'd heard the same line repeated a thousand times from a thousand soon-to-be-dead faces. A few scraps with fists, rocks, and maybe the occasional dagger wasn't a real battle. Until they'd survived a Dullahan ambush, or been on the receiving end of a Centaur charge, no one had the right to claim they were experienced.

But it suited his point.

"Good in a fight? Well, perhaps you'd fit in with the Raverian fighters. Or if you know magic, why *not* enlist with the Tanglelurk company? But if you do, you'll be on the front, mark me. The first clash will have you going up against experienced warriors. Veterans who've killed more people than

you have fingers. So I wouldn't bet a 'few fights' against a skilled [Halberdier], not for any odds."

That took the wind out of the young man's sails. Quallet turned, nodding at the two recruiters he'd just made enemies of.

"They'll promise you gold for nothing, but it won't be all of you who see it after months of fighting. Which is why I'm telling you to join *my* company."

"And what does your company have that they don't?"

That came from a brown-skinned Centaur with white fur standing at the back of the crowd. He had a good bit of room, mainly because Centaurs were huge and touchy. The Humans looked especially leery of him. Quallet replied calmly, meeting the Centaur's gaze.

"I'm the [Captain] of Gravetender's Fist. Haven't heard of it? That's fine. But we're a *suppression* company. We don't go to battle against veterans. We're night-duty, corpse battlers. You know what I'm talking about."

They did. The Lizardfolk shifted and some looked back towards the other recruiters. A few Dullahans turned away. The Centaurs were still listening although their faces had twisted with disgust. The Humans were... staring blankly. Did they not know, or just not care? Quallet took a breath.

This was the hard part. Lose too many Lizardfolk and you'd lose them all. The Dullahans were hard to sell to. He could probably get the Centaurs either way, but Quallet wanted all the recruits here. If he got them, he wouldn't have to go through any more villages and stand in the hot air.

"Not fans of what my company does? I won't blame you. But we provide an important service, a *necessary* service for most companies. You've heard of the battle between the Razorshard Armor company and the Roving Arrow company, haven't you? I'm bound for that battlefield after this village, and I'll be leading my company onto the battlefield each night. It won't be glamorous—it'll be muck and death and filth—but it will be *safe*."

What an ironic word. But it was true, and it drew attention back to him. Quallet strode back and forth, speaking to the crowd as they watched him.

“Yes, safe! As safe as war can be! You’ll see combat, true enough, but you won’t die like Bloodflies in *my* company. Eight out of every ten raw recruits that serves under me survives their first month. If you’re new to battle, you’ll gain your first ten levels in a combat class in this company, my oath on it!”

He alone could boast that. Quallet knew, the other recruiters knew, and most of the recruits with a brain knew that signing up with a company meant gambling your life if you were a new recruit. Put your mark with the Raverian Fighters and you’d be fighting on the front lines within the week, and you’d be lucky indeed if you didn’t run up against a high-level soldier, a [Mage], or simply got cut to pieces in the crush. But Gravetender’s Fist and companies like the one Quallet ran were different.

They were safe. For a given measure of safe, of course. And that had an allure that beat out all of the other recruiters’ desperate calls and pitches. Quallet got down to the details as the others stayed. He nearly had them.

“You’ll earn a silver piece for every night you spend fighting, and four copper coins for the nights you don’t. Think its poor pay for a soldier? We’ll give you lot a sword and armor if you don’t have it, healing potions for your wounds, and I’ll be fighting right alongside you all. My company begins leaving tomorrow morning. Ask as many questions as you like. And ask about—I’ll swear to a truth crystal all I’ve said is true. If you’re unsure, ask those other recruiters what your odds are. But if they’re honest, they’ll tell you my company is the way to go for those of you who want to survive.”

Quallet pointed at the haggard [Sergeant] recruiting for the Raverian fighters. The man gave him a haunted look as Quallet raised his voice.

“Over there lies glory. Glory. The glory of the brave and the *dead*. If you’re seeking battles to test your mettle, sign up by all means. But join my company if you prefer to fight and live.”

It worked. It always worked, especially when you had an ill-fated company you could point at as a reminder of what could go wrong. Tales of glory and fame on the battlefield were all very well if everyone was humming the same tune, but Quallet had learnt to be the one dissenting voice in the crowd. And people *listened* to the one odd voice.

He didn't get all the recruits of course. No one ever did. Well, perhaps Niers Astoragon or Valka Cerethrian might be able to pull it off if they walked into the recruiting grounds. But that night Quallet signed over eighty recruits into his company, effectively doubling its size.

It wasn't a bad haul, all told. He'd gotten the Centaurs—all of them. It turned out the one who'd spoken was a Level 11 [Fighter], and his friends had a few levels between them, which was good. Quallet had a handful of Dullahans, and a sizeable number of Lizardfolk. One of them had a magic class, which was an unexpected little gift.

As for the rest? The Humans had come almost as one entire package. They were odd, and signed their names on Quallet's enchanted list with odd flourishes and curved writing, as if they were all [Scribes]. Some had laughed as they'd did so, and joked about 'enlisting' as if it were a completely new thing.

Odd. Quallet hoped he wasn't borrowing trouble with their lot. But they didn't seem like former [Bandits] or troublemakers in the ways he'd learned to watch out for. They were just weird.

He didn't have to like them, just teach them how to fight and obey orders, anyways. Quallet marched his new recruits two miles out to the camp where he and the rest of the Gravetender's Fist company was located.

Rows of tents and armed warriors lounging about were what greeted the recruits. Quallet saw two people—a Dullahan [Sergeant] named Xor and a Human [Soldier], Raeh, stride over to meet him. They were Quallet's acting officers. He didn't need many, but people who could lead when he was away were important, and he knew both males, having served with them before.

"That's the rest of our company, Quallet?"

Raeh didn't bother with formalities. Quallet didn't see the need, at least between officers. He nodded at Raeh, and the man grinned. He wasn't a big

man, although he was very good with the sword he used.

“Finally. Time to be moving at last. I was getting bored of being eaten by the damn jungle.”

Xor looked disapproving. He *did* address Quallet formally, as Dullahans tended to do in every situation.

“Captain Quallet, there have been no disturbances in your absence. Would you like me to instruct the recruits, or will you do so?”

“I’ll do it.”

Quallet turned and spoke loudly to the group of recruits. The Humans had been staring around and the Lizardfolk had already sat down while the Dullahans stood at attention. The Centaurs just looked bored at the slow pace. Each race had its peculiarities.

“This is where you lot will sleep tonight! You’re all part of Gravetender’s Fist now, and you’re under my command. I promised you food and a place to sleep—and armor and weapons! You’ll get all that, but for now mill about. Some of you will be called out by these two men—”

He indicated Raeh and Xor.

“They are my officers and you’ll hop to it when they give you orders, just as you would when I tell you to do something! But there’s no fighting tonight. Tomorrow you’ll march and we’ll start training you before we get to the battlefield. You’ll have a good four days to practice.”

“Four days?”

Some of the Humans looked dismayed. Quallet laughed.

“Four isn’t enough? You’d rather practice for a month? Don’t worry, we’ll beat the fundamentals into you, and you’ll get a class while marching if you haven’t one already. Your opponents won’t be that dangerous either, as you’ll see. But for now—eat! Food will be passed around shortly. Talk amongst yourselves if you want to, make friends. Everyone standing here will be fighting by your side and might save your life!”

The recruits looked around warily. Quallet wondered if they’d mingle. It didn’t usually happen. He went over a few more rules, trying to get it over with as succinctly as possible.

“You’ll each get one meal and *one* alone. There’ll be no stealing, or fighting of any kind in my company. I’ll personally see to *that*. If you can’t stand someone’s guts, keep away from them and hope they get killed soon. But cause trouble and I’ll thrash you myself. You’re soldiers in a company now, not children.”

That was it. Quallet let the recruits disperse, mingling with the few veterans and other new soldiers from other villages he’d already found. It was rare for most of his soldiers to stay more than a few months in Gravetender’s Fist. Quallet had grown used to new faces coming and going.

“Let’s feed them.”

He grunted to Xor and the Dullahan helped him unload the bags of holding that helped make Quallet’s company. They had been very dear to buy, but it allowed Quallet to do away with a lot of expenses for wagons, instead bringing out preserved food to be shared around by soldiers under Raeh’s watchful eye.

Recruits ate, recruits talked, some bragging nervously, others swapping tales or just keeping to themselves. Quallet watched as he chewed down some sour-dough bread and cheese, biting into one of the fleshy Picta-fruits and washing it all down with warm water. He swatted at insects as he saw each of the four races sticking to their groups for the most part.

It was good enough. It was like normal. Quallet went to his private tent as the new soldiers slept in the mostly insect-proof tents. The experienced [Captain] listened to the dull roar of the jungle’s wildlife, the occasional breeze blowing through the area, and the sound of snoring. He slept.

The next day, Quallet rose just after dawn, and with his two officers, got his soldiers up. They awoke, scratching at bites, moaning, probably regretting ever wanting to be a soldier.

That was normal too. Quallet fed them, showed the new recruits how to break down camp, stored it all in the bags of holding, loaded the heavy artifacts onto the lone wagon his company used, and moved out.

His routine was simple. Quallet wished he could follow it in his sleep. After he recruited his company back to a good strength, after buying supplies to last for weeks or months and cramming them in the bags of holding, filling their enchanted capacity to the brim, he took his command

and headed towards the closest battlefield, or the one he'd been contracted to.

This time he was headed towards the place where the Razorshard Armor company and the Roving Arrow company were fighting. A Dullahan-led company and a Centaur company, respectively. They were fighting over land, or maybe it was some old feud. Gold? Quallet hadn't heard the details from the other [Mercenary Captain] who'd tipped him off. All he knew was that they could use another suppression company. The fighting had been fierce, apparently.

March his recruits. Arm them with cheap weapons scavenged from the battlefield or bought en-masse from the war vendors. Train them.

That came at the series of breaks to let the weary soldiers rest their feet. Quallet first distributed armor, letting the recruits fight over who got what, and then arms. For some reason, all the young men seemed to fancy themselves swordsmen, for all that there were perfectly good axes. Quallet eyed his new command again.

Lizardfolk, Dullahans, Centaurs, Humans, he all had in various numbers. But the largest influx of Humans had come from that odd group of strangely-dressed young men—and young women—who'd come with him on the latest recruiting drive. They were...strange.

For one thing, they all seemed to know each other. If not each other by name, they shared some kind of connection Quallet couldn't fathom. Some had very strange clothing, quite inappropriate for Baleros' weather and stinging insects. Any fool knew to cover skin rather than flaunt it, but this lot had been practically devoured by the biting insects the first night.

Too, some of them had odd artifacts that were clearly magical. They made noise and light, and Quallet had seen more than one Lizardfolk edge over curiously. The Humans were very protective though, and didn't show them to anyone.

Were they rich? Or were the artifacts cheap toys to make sound and light? Either way, it was strange. The Humans stared about at everything as if they'd never *seen* a real sword before, or another species. Still, they were hardly worse than any other recruit, which was why as the sun rose to midday, Quallet decided to start instructing them how to *use* the weapons

he'd given them. Some of the young men had cut themselves, a few badly, by mock-fencing with the swords they'd been given.

He looked across his command and found one of the Humans who caught his eye. He stood out, mainly because everyone else who'd joined up had pale skin, tan skin, brown skin, or dark skin...this young man who was a bit older than most had dark black skin, like charcoal. Quallet called out to him.

"You there! Black-skin."

The young man stiffened. He turned as Quallet strode towards him, looking surprised. And for some reason, angry.

"What did you call me?"

He was taller than Quallet, a giant, at least six feet, possibly six and a half feet tall. He had long arms, and a muscled body, although he seemed not to be at all comfortable with the mace he'd been given.

"I said you. You with the black skin."

Quallet spoke calmly as the young man seemed to grow angrier. He pointed at the group of resting Humans milling about.

"Get some of your friends together. Twenty of them. We're starting arms drills now."

What was wrong? Quallet had given an order. He hadn't insulted the young man, but in some way, he *had*. The black-skinned young man looked upset. Was it because Quallet's skin was light, tanned from days in the sun? It didn't matter either way. Quallet stared up at the younger man, adding a touch of [Commanding Presence] until he backed down.

"Yes sir. I will do that just now. Sir."

Perhaps it was the way he had said it—he spoke as if he didn't understand the common tongue quite right, which was incredible in itself—but Quallet watched as the young man walked off. Apparently, 'just now' didn't mean much to him, because he took his sweet time before obeying Quallet's orders.

It turned out his name was Luan, and he did eventually bring some nervous, giggling young men to Quallet for a demonstration.

“Here’s how you hold those shiny weapons you’ve been given. You lot—take out your weapons. Not like that! Watch me, now. If you’re taking your axe out, or your sword, you’ll want to do it fast. Like *this*.”

He demonstrated and made the young men do everything from take out their weapons to hold them correctly. Then Quallet had them swing at the air, at trees and stumps, making them get a feel for how the weapons moved and how to strike.

The Lizardfolk, Dullahans, Centaurs...it was the Humans who were the problem. Again. The young men that Luan had gathered treated Quallet’s orders like a game, laughing and slashing the air with wild cuts that wouldn’t have killed anyone. One of them, standing down the line as Quallet shouted at Luan—who at least had a good grip and stance—was swinging his sword around and laughing at the others.

Quallet turned to address this idiot when the young man’s hands, sweaty from the heat and exercise, slipped on the badly-wrapped leather hilt of the sword. He lost his grip and there was a scream from one of the young women as the sword went flying through the air. People scattered out of the way as the sword landed in the dirt. The young man who’d been holding it grinned nervously.

“Oops.”

Some of his friends laughed, but Quallet’s eyes narrowed. He crossed the distance between him and the young man in an instant. The young man didn’t see the gauntleted fist before it split his lip and sent him tumbling to the ground.

The laughter stopped. Quallet heard the young man swearing and stood over him, one hand on his axe. Everyone else watched as the young man stared up, suddenly afraid. Quallet shouted at him.

“This is not a game! When you’re fighting for your life, having a proper grip on your sword will save your life, and the lives of the soldiers around you! If you cannot take this seriously, I will leave you in this forest to rot!”

The pale-skinned youth flinched from his words. Quallet turned and faced the rest of his company.

“Mark me, this is *not* a joke. You are learning how to fight! Hold your weapons properly, get a feel for them. Because you will be *seeing combat this week!*”

The young man got up, pale-faced and bleeding. No one spoke. Quallet pointed.

“Pick up your blade and keep practicing! You! Yes, you lot! Don’t just stand around! Get moving! I want to see you—all of you—practicing!”

He made the rest of his company do the same, feeling the eyes of the Humans and Luan on his back. Now they feared him, which was fine. A [Captain] could be feared. Quallet was just glad he’d had the opportunity to impress on them that this wasn’t a game. With luck, he’d have another opportunity before it came to battle as well. Every time he showed these raw soldiers what fighting was like, was another life he’d save when it came to their first night on duty.

“You! Wood-armor. Yes, you. Get the tents set up. Get as many hands as you need, but until they’re up, you lot don’t sleep!”

Quallet barked orders as his weary and sore company rested for the night. He made them set up camp, pass around food, and then let them pass out in their tents. Quallet slept easily, woke up the next day and began it all over again.

Train them, march them, feed them, and then let them rest. On the second day, Quallet began to lecture his company on their duties and had a nasty surprise.

“You mean you don’t *know* what Gravetender’s Fist does?”

He stared at the group of Humans in disbelief. They looked ashamed, but it was true. To everyone’s astonishment, it seemed that while the Humans had understood what being in a mercenary company meant, they hadn’t known what a suppression company—which was what they were in—did.

Quallet's eyes narrowed as he looked at the rows of faces, trying to see if they were playing a prank on him. But it didn't look like they were. The other species were giving the Humans very odd looks too.

Greener than he'd thought. Or maybe from another continent? But why would they be stranded all the way out here, then? Either way, Quallet amended his time-adhered to speech.

"If you signed up without knowing exactly what Gravetender's Fist does, well, you should have figured it out from the name. Alone. Grave tending. Gravetender. It's not exactly hard to see the connection. Understand?"

Blank looks. Quallet couldn't *believe* this.

"The undead! The restless souls that rise from unburied corpses and in places of power! Have you never seen one before?"

They hadn't. Xor had to actually rub at his head's eyes with his hands and Raeh looked incredulous. The other Lizardfolk were staring at the Humans as if they were idiots. The Centaurs were making a joke of the entire thing as they laughed amongst themselves.

"The dead rise. Zombies, skeletons, ghouls...they get worse with time and depending on the corpse and amount of death. A [Necromancer] can raise them and command them, but undead will spawn naturally from unburied corpses. That might not be a problem in a quiet village where the dead can be laid to rest—or cremated—but this is *Baleros*. A place where war is always present! We're headed towards a battlefield where two companies—with thousands or tens of thousands of soldiers—are fighting each day! What do you *think* will happen to all those bodies?"

"They rise?"

How could anyone ask that like a question? Quallet scowled.

"Of course they do. And they're not only a nuisance, but a *danger*. Leave a battlefield full of thousands of corpses alone for a short period and you'll get ghouls and worse popping up within days. They'll attack soldiers, spread disease—and that's where we come in."

He nodded to Raeh and the man took over.

“Gravetender’s Fist. We are a suppression company. That’s not like a regular company for you new recruits. Suppression companies specialize in one kind of fighting. Some kill Goblins or monsters that make a nuisance of themselves. Others, like our company, kill the undead on the battlefield.”

There were murmurs at that. Quallet watched the Humans warily. If they hadn’t known—how could they not know? But now he had to worry about them deserting too. He spoke crisply, trying to dismiss their sudden dismay.

“I said it was better work than fighting, didn’t I? You’ll be up against zombies and the like mostly. Nothing dangerous. A rotting corpse might be a threat, but it’s better than a veteran with a magical blade. Each night when the fighting stops we’ll go into the battlefield, between the armies often, and handle the dead. The soldiers fighting don’t want to do it—they’re tired, and if both armies are sending troops out it’ll be a night battle against the undead and each other. So that’s why companies like this one are hired.”

“Clean up duty.”

Someone in the crowd joked. Quallet nodded, ignoring the levity.

“We’ll be collecting corpses, burning them, and putting down any undead that decide to get up. It will be dirty work, quick, and dangerous if you don’t watch each other’s back. But the worst you’ll face out there is a Ghoul, and that’s only if you’re unlucky. It beats dying with an arrow in your neck when the real fighting starts in the mornings, mark me.”

The Humans stirred uneasily, as did some others in his company. Quallet raised his voice.

“That’s why we’re practicing! Now, your duties are simple. You’ll be working in teams, spread out to cover ground. If you find a body—you bring it over. Yes, they’ll be rotting, yes it will *smell*. And you will stab it through the head before you come, in case it’s rising. [Sergeant] Xor’s done this work a hundred times. He’ll instruct you. Xor, show them how to move with Raeh watching your back...”

They met the first group of undead on the road, a day before reaching the battleground. The shambling zombies must have missed the armies somehow, and they were roaming about aimlessly. It was a perfect opportunity, one Quallet had hoped for. He took command and ordered his company to engage them. Not all of course; it was only about thirty zombies, so Quallet took exactly that number out and had them fight.

They were all frightened, most close to wetting themselves as the zombies approached. But Quallet had chosen well, and the Centaur with white fur and the Lizardgirl with magic killed their zombie quickly and efficiently. Watched by Quallet, Xor, and Raeh, the other raw soldiers fought and killed their zombies, hacking away, running back, screaming—

Learning to fight. It was messy, horrible to watch from the eye of an experienced veteran, but it was the first step to forging his company into a fighting force. Quallet nodded approvingly as one young man killed a zombie with an axe.

“A good first step.”

He was one of the odd Humans, the ones with weird clothing. This one was pale-skinned and had odd features. Narrower eyes, black hair—he was a bit short as well and he had an expensive-looking long-sleeved shirt and pants on. They looked like fine material, but they were now covered in guts and gore underneath the battered leather armor he was wearing. Quallet didn't know the young man's story, and he didn't care what his name was.

He'd heard others call the young man Ken, though. Ken...although one of the young women had called him something else. What was it? Ken... Ken...something.

Kenjiro Murata stumbled away as the zombie he'd killed sunk to the ground, its misshapen head collapsing inwards as it struck the ground. It couldn't really be called a head at all, in fact. Kenjiro, or 'Ken' as the others called him, had bashed it so many times with the axe he'd been given that the rotting bone and flesh around the skull had caved in.

He stared at the corpse as it fell, stared at the horrible innards of its head, smelled the rotting flesh, saw some things *wriggling* in the decomposing corpse's open mouth. Ken turned, about to vomit, when he heard a familiar voice crying out.

“No! No!”

He ran towards the voice, leaving the dead zombie behind. Ken saw a girl with short black hair, wearing a battered piece of armor awkwardly over her jeans and t-shirt, backing away from another dead zombie.

It had a spear lodged in its belly. But it was still trying to move forwards. The girl backed away, screaming, and then shouting at the undead corpse in a language no one but Kenjiro understood.

“やめて. やめてください!”

Her voice was shrill, panicked. There was something insane about what she'd said. Stop. Please, stop. She'd said it to a zombie, but she probably couldn't believe what was happening. Ken still couldn't himself.

“Aiko-san!”

He ran over. The axe was in his hands. Ken smashed the zombie in the head, feeling a sickening connection. It fell over, and the girl turned away, covering her face in her hands. Ken stepped back, shaking as the second zombie he'd killed fell, twitching and making a gurgling sound. He looked hesitantly at the girl.

Aiko Nonomura.

She was crying, sobbing, actually, with fear and horror. Ken opened his mouth to say something, and then closed it. He didn't know what to say, not to Aiko. He wouldn't have known what to tell himself.

He was in another world, with magic and monsters. And the undead. He was a soldier, and so was she.

They hadn't known what they were signing up for at all.

Aiko kept crying as the angry [Captain] shouted at the people around them. Ken saw other people, some Humans like him, others wearing strange armor, Dullahans, fighting next to scaly lizard-people as galloping Centaurs ran by, spearing zombies and hacking them apart.

“Aiko-san, are you okay? 大丈夫ですか?”

Ken had a hard time speaking English, so he switched back to his native tongue, feeling oddly formal. He knew Aiko of course, but she wasn't someone he *knew*.

She wasn't a childhood friend, more like a classmate that Ken knew from sharing the same class with for multiple years throughout their junior and senior high school time. They hadn't spoken much. It was a fluke that had put them together in the airport on that fateful day when they'd vanished from their world into this one.

Now they were alone, and Aiko was the only one who understood him.

“Yes. Yes, I—”

She spoke in English, speaking to Ken and also to the Lizardgirl who'd stopped to see if they were alright. The scaly, frilled head nodded and the Lizardgirl walked on, conjuring a ball of fire to throw at a zombie. Ken watched her with amazement in his heart, and then looked at Aiko.

“Are you okay? Hurt?”

She shook her head, but Aiko was clearly far from alright. She was pale, and as she looked back at the zombie, Aiko's face turned dead white. She stepped back and put a hand to her mouth.

But she didn't throw up. Instead, Aiko looked at Ken, a mortal horror in her eyes. He recognized it, because it was the same terrible feeling in him.

Zombies were real. Magic was real. They were in a fantasy world. Only it wasn't wonderful. It was just as bad as any anime, only worse. Because Ken could *smell* the rotting corpses. He could feel every insect bite on his body, feel the heat of Baleros' winter, and know that he had killed two people today.

Maybe they were already dead. But the sensation of breaking flesh and bone was—it was too much.

“悪因悪果.”

Aiko gave word to the feeling in Ken's stomach. He looked at her. She'd said—well, he couldn't process it in English, only in his native language. It was an expression. It meant, roughly, evil sown is evil reaped.

Those who do bad things have bad things happen to them. He shook his head.

“ううん...”

She stared at him. Ken felt compelled to explain himself. He looked at Aiko, hesitated, and then spoke rapidly in Japanese.

“If this were karma, surely we’d be punished in some other way. No, this is just reality. It is harsh, but we must survive.”

Ever since they’d come to this world, they’d had to survive. They’d sold their backpacks and luggage, found food and shelter for a few days, but like the others, like everyone from this world, they’d run out of money in an instant. This had been the only work they could take, the only work they could do.

“It is too cruel. I cannot do this.”

Aiko’s eyes were still brimming with tears. She looked at the corpse, gagged. Ken tried to look, and failed. He spoke to Aiko, trying to suppress the feeling in his stomach.

“They are dead, Aiko. If they were alive, I would feel guilty. But they are dead and we are...warriors now.”

He had the class. He was a Level 1 [Warrior]. A voice in his head had told him he had the class last night, and a Skill—[Lesser Stamina]. Perhaps that was why his arms weren’t burning despite chopping at two zombies with the axe?

“I know! I know, but I cannot—Kenjiro-san, why are we here?”

Aiko was distraught. She stared at the zombies, and Ken had nothing he could tell her. He didn’t know. One second they’d been in the Tullamarine Airport in Melbourne, standing around and making awkward conversation as the rest of their group went off to buy souvenirs. Ken and Aiko had been forced to watch everyone’s luggage because they’d lost the straw pick. Some other people had been walking by, and Ken had seen a flash—

The next moment, he’d been standing in a jungle with Aiko and a group of over a hundred confused people, spread out across a mile’s landscape. That had been their first moments in Baleros.

It hadn't gotten much better since then.

Movement. Something approached out of the corner of Ken's eye and he whirled, holding his axe like Quallet had taught him. But it wasn't a zombie.

"Whoa. Careful."

Someone was coming towards them. Another Human. This young man looked older than both Ken and Aiko, who were both freshmen in university. The tall, black-skinned young man holding a mace and wearing rusted chainmail grinned at them, sweating heavily. There was something stuck on one side of the mace. Ken stared at it, and then at the young man.

"Luan-san?"

The young man grinned and Ken knew he'd gotten the name right.

"Yes, and you're...Ken. Kenjiro, right?"

He didn't use honorifics. He wasn't Japanese, but from somewhere else. No one from Japan had been taken to the other world that Kenjiro had seen. Ken nodded.

"I am...and this is Aiko-san."

Aiko bowed slightly, and Luan grinned at her. There was so much absurdity to the moment, as the two Japanese students introduced themselves over the corpse of a zombie. But it was normal, so they clung to that.

Luan eyed the dead zombie and then Ken and Aiko.

"I saw you two fighting. Are you alright?"

How could you answer that? Ken hesitated, and then fell back on politeness.

"I am fine."

"Yes, I am okay. Thank you very much."

Aiko spoke with slightly accented English, stumbling a bit over the words. Neither she nor Ken were native speakers, although they'd done well in English class. Luan's eyes flickered to them, and he nodded without addressing their blatant lie.

“I am glad you two are okay. You should stick with me and the others.”

He pointed, and Ken saw some of the other people he recognized, standing pale and sweaty a good distance away from the last zombies as they were put to rest. He followed Luan with Aiko and they heard Quallet bellowing at them.

“Good! We’ll have a break to drink and clean yourselves off, and then we’ll tell you what you did right—and what you did wrong!”

“I hate that guy.”

Luan made a face as he led Ken towards the others. Ken privately agreed, although he wouldn’t have said as much out loud. He nodded awkwardly towards the others as he heard one of them, an American named Johanas, talking loudly.

“We did it! We killed those fucking zombies. I mean, *we* did it. With swords and axes, like a fucking video game. Does this mean we’ll level up? What hell, man. What the *hell* is going on?”

That seemed to be the general consensus of the group. Everyone, even the people who hadn’t fought, were pale and shaken. Ken understood.

They’d known they were enlisting to be soldiers, but they hadn’t expected *this*. Somehow, Ken had thought it wouldn’t be...wouldn’t be... wouldn’t be real. He’d still clung to a hope that this was all a dream, and that having a world with classes and levels and people with Skills meant this was a game, or some kind of dream you could wake up from.

But it was all real. And from the looks on the others’ faces, they were beginning to realize this as well. Ken and Aiko stood around with the others, listening to them speak. Everyone was speaking in English, as it was the tongue all of them had in common.

“This is some crazy shit, huh?”

Someone was talking to him. Ken stared at the young man with blonde hair who was speaking, and tried to make sense of what he’d said. Crazy... oh, he was saying this was insane. Ken nodded.

“I think...this is very crazy, yes.”

“I thought this would be different. I thought since we had classes and levels, we wouldn’t actually *kill* people. Or it wouldn’t be that real. But this is totally like...like Sword Art Online, you know? Sort of like that, don’t you think?”

What had he said? Ken was trying to keep up. He hesitated.

“Oh? Yes? Maybe. I do not know. I am sorry...”

Ken saw the other young man blink in surprise.

“Sorry? No, it’s cool. I mean...”

He trailed off and the conversation ended there. Aiko edged towards Ken and whispered to him.

“What did he mean? What is...”

She hesitated and spoke the words awkwardly in English.

“...‘Sword Art Online?’”

“I think it is an anime.”

“Oh. Did you watch it? Do you know what it is about?”

“No.”

They both fell silent. It wasn’t as if Ken *didn’t* watch any anime, and he’d certainly read a few manga over the years. But he was in college now, and watching anime was a bit...well, there was more to do than just that.

He watched the young man with blonde hair move back towards the others. The others like him. It wasn’t that the group of Humans who’d come from another world weren’t all on the same boat, but they *were* different.

They’d all been in the Melbourne Airport when taken, and so they were all sorts of nationalities. Some big groups of travelers had been caught up, while individual travelers had been seized as well, or parts of groups like Ken and Aiko.

Most of them were either Australian or American, with a heavier emphasis on American, since a huge tour group had been coming through. Other nationalities had come as well of course, but they were fragmented.

Some had already left. In the first moments of confusion when Aiko had screamed and people had cried out and come running, Ken had seen all

kinds of faces. But when it had been established that no one knew what was happening or what was going on, people began forming their own groups, usually based on shared nationality or some other identity.

When they'd finally gotten a fire going and lit up the jungle with their phones and other devices, Ken and Aiko had stuck with the others, trying to speak English and explain where they were from. A lot of kids from India had kept to themselves and didn't speak to others much. They vanished on the first day.

In the days that followed as the travelers from another world tried to find civilization, more people left, suspicious or afraid they'd been caught up in a trap. They departed secretly in the night, or openly in larger groups.

A little over half of the original number had stayed together. The Americans, Australians, and some other people from European countries stuck together, and a lot of other people from countries with no friends came as well. Ken and Aiko followed the majority because they had no idea what to do.

Now of course, after deciding as a group to sign up as soldiers in order to eat and survive, everyone still didn't know what to do. But they did talk among each other anxiously.

"Hey. I have water for you two. Need some?"

The tall young man named Luan was back, with water flasks. Ken thanked him profusely before taking his and washing his filthy hands. Aiko did the same on the spear she'd recovered from the zombie, splashing water carelessly on it until Xor shouted at her not to waste supplies. She jumped, and Luan scowled in his direction.

"Asshole. You know, I haven't seen him smile once? Apparently all Dullahans are like that. Do you know them? Their legends, I mean."

Ken blinked at Luan. The other young man was clearly not from America—there was something about the way he spoke, and how he didn't fit with the other Americans. He wasn't from any of the other major groups either, because he didn't talk with them all the time. Ken nodded slowly, trying to reply as best he could.

“I do know. But they are...how can I say this? Fairy tale? They are... not-real things. Stories. Or so I thought.”

Luan nodded.

“Some of the guys are saying they think they’re like monsters.”

“Like monsters?”

Ken turned and stared at some of the other Dullahan recruits. They had taken their heads off their armored bodies and were pouring water into their mouths. They could take their heads *off* their bodies, leaving only a glowing light from within. He spoke hesitantly.

“I think they are people like us, but they look so much like—like... Aiko, how do I say—?”

He conferred with Aiko and turned to Luan.

“Like walking armor, yes? Like knight armor, from Western culture?”

Luan’s face lit up and he grinned.

“Oh! Yeah, I get it. I was thinking they looked a bit like Alfonse. You know, from Full Metal Alchemist, yeah? I loved that anime!”

Ken and Aiko stared at him blankly. Ken nodded slowly.

“I think I know what you are saying. But Aiko and I—”

He broke off and conferred with Aiko. She hadn’t seen it either. Rather than be surprised at their lack of encyclopedic knowledge of all things anime, Luan laughed.

“That’s okay. I’m a bit of a weeaboo. Do you know that word?”

Someone obsessed with Japanese culture. Ken nodded and smiled.

“I like anime, but I have not watched many recently. But Aiko and I agree—this is like an anime.”

“A horrible one.”

Aiko’s face was pale as she sipped from the water canteen. Luan nodded, growing serious.

“This is some bad shit, mate. I was worried about you two when Quallet told you to fight, but you did well! You stabbed that guy right through the

stomach! Bam!”

He demonstrated and Aiko’s face went pale again. Luan put a hand on her shoulder, making her jump at the unexpected contact.

“Sorry. I know this is all horrific.”

“No, it’s okay—”

She hesitated, and Ken realized she didn’t remember Luan’s name. To cover for her, he hastily spoke up.

“This is Luan-san, Aiko. And I am Kenjiro. I am very pleased to meet you.”

He bowed slightly to Luan, who then smiled and introduced himself.

“I’m Luan Khumalo. You two are from Japan, yes?”

“Yes. Where are you from, Luan-san?”

“You can call me Luan. I’m from South Africa.”

“Oh! What place in south Africa?”

Luan paused, and Ken saw Aiko cover her face and start laughing at him. It took Luan a moment to explain, and then Kenjiro’s face turned red.

“Oh. I am so sorry!”

Ken bowed his head, feeling flushed with embarrassment. But Luan only laughed heartily.

“It’s fine, it’s fine! I’ve met a lot of people who have no idea South Africa is a place.”

Thus, they became friends. As Quallet stood everyone up and lectured them at a roar on how to fight better next time, and then marched them onwards, Ken and Aiko began talking to Luan as the company moved down the jungle trails.

Luan was the first person they’d really got to know, and he was well-spoken, friendly, and strong. He carried his weapon and walked without succumbing to the heat, which was apparently, aside from the humidity, cooler than back home. Ken felt like he was in Okinawa, and he’d never *been* to Okinawa.

“Your English is really good. I am very jealous.”

Aiko commented to Luan as they were on the road. He smiled knowingly.

“Yes. It is, isn’t it? I grew up speaking English.”

“Really?”

They stared at him. Luan laughed again.

“I can speak four languages. English, Afrikaans, Zulu, Tswana...you can speak two, right?”

“Yes, but not good.”

Ken was acutely aware of how hard it was to speak with other people in English, and had kept silent up until now because of it. But Luan took the opposite view.

“Even if one is not as good as the other, that should be a good thing, not a bad thing. Most of these Americans can only speak one. If there were other people from Africa around, I could speak about them behind their backs.”

Ken and Aiko laughed, and then immediately looked around to see if anyone had heard. No one had.

The group they were in, the group of people from another world was indeed filled with Americans. They were the majority, and in a way, they’d taken charge. Several of them, mainly guys, seemed to have the final say in what was going on. They’d been the ones to suggest signing up with Quallet, and they were the most vocal, and thus, the most persuasive, members of the group.

They were also the most ready to be fighting. Some hadn’t been bothered at all by killing zombies, talking about this being like a movie or T.V. show, and seemed positively happy about the prospect of leveling up and fighting. By contrast, Ken and Aiko would have loved to *de-enlist* from Gravatender’s Fist, but they were stuck. Luan seemed to share their opinions.

“What did you two do when you were in our world?”

“We are...were students in university.”

“Oh, right! How old are you?”

Ken was twenty one, Aiko twenty two. Both of them were in the same classes. Luan grinned when he realized they had known each other all their lives.

“You two got into the same university?”

“That’s right. I was studying to be in business and Aiko-san—”

“I was trying to learn to be an artist. Not manga—I do illustrations.”

“Ag, shame! That’s great.”

“Shame?”

The two of them looked blank. What Luan said made no sense—until he explained.

“Shame means good in South Africa. It’s like if you said—I found twenty bucks, yeah? Then I’d say, ‘Shame!’”

“Oh. I think I understand...”

Perhaps it was because they were both from different cultures that Ken and Aiko felt at home speaking with Luan. Unlike the people from America, they were alike in how they were all foreigners, outsiders to the main group. Aiko asked the obvious question to Luan.

“What did you do, Luan?”

He grinned, showing them very white teeth.

“Oh, me? I was on my country’s national Olympic rowing team.”

It took a few seconds for Ken to interpret this. When he did, he tripped. Aiko’s eyes went wide.

“*Eh? What?*”

They stared. It took a while and Luan had to explain himself several times, but the world of Olympic paddling slowly opened itself up to the two Japanese students.

Luan was an Olympic contender. Not an Olympian—he hadn’t gone to the Olympics, but he would have in 2020. He was South Africa’s first hope for a Silver or Gold medal in his event, the single scull.

He had trained to be part of a Coxless pair, which was a specialized type of boat that allowed for two paddlers to use it at the same time. Luan was usually on the bow side—which was to say, the left side of the boat—and competed with his good friend, Ben, who had the same goal as Luan. They wanted to take home the gold medal in the next Olympics, and had trained themselves intensively until they had become a serious contender, despite South Africa only having ever won one gold medal in the rowing event in the Olympics.

Being part of a coxless pair was extremely difficult, because Luan and Ben both had to balance each other and cooperate to move and row with the same force to go fast through the water. Luan had originally wanted to compete as a single scull—a type of event where only one person rowed with two paddles—but he'd met Ben while training and the two had become instant best friends.

However, because there were already two excellent paddlers forming a coxless pair who'd won a Silver-medal in the 2016 Summer Olympics, Lawrence Brittain and Shaun Keeling, Luan had put his hopes on winning in the single scull event, and his times were good enough for him to seriously aim at the gold medal. He'd been in Australia for a break when he'd been transported to another world.

"You know, it's shitty lucky, but at least Ben will get a chance to go instead of me, eh? He's dreamed of being an Olympian as long as I have."

Luan said all of this so casually that Ken couldn't believe it. Luan was—well, he was one of *the* best paddlers in the world. He was an athlete—which also explained why he didn't seem fazed by the marching or fighting like the others.

Ken had no idea how to behave with Luan, until Aiko pointed out what should have been obvious.

"You are a good friend. I hope we will go back in time for the Olympics, and you can compete and win!"

"Yeah. Me too."

Luan smiled at Aiko and looked ahead. There was a quiet worry in his eyes, though, and Ken saw it. Luan turned to them, serious, as the final day of their march wound to a close.

“You two should stick together with me. It’s going to be bad up ahead. I don’t think the others realize it, but that Quallet guy and the other experienced soldiers know it too. Our job is going to be dangerous no matter what he says.”

“But he said we will be safe, right? Safer? We will only fight zombies, not other people.”

Ken tried to swallow the fear that had jumped up in his gut. He would have liked Luan to lie in that moment, but the tall South African young man looked down at him. He was older than both Ken and Aiko by several years. He was twenty five, and there was something knowing in his eyes.

“It’s a war, Ken. Believe me, wars are never safe.”

The next day they arrived at the battlefield, a wide valley many kilometers long, where two armies sortied from camps on hilltops and met in the valley floor. Hundreds of bodies fell each hour and the screaming—

Oh, the screaming.

Quallet knew he’d come close when he heard the sounds of mage spells in the distance. There was a rhythmic *thump* of something extremely powerful hitting the ground. He immediately signaled a halt.

“Raise the banner!”

It was essential to do this straight away. Each company had a banner and raising it was the only way to identify themselves. It might not mean they were safe, but an unmarked group wandering around would definitely be attacked by all sides. Under a banner, Gravetender’s Fist was at least nominally protected.

“We’re headed into a battlefield, but we are *not* fighting anyone living. The first soldier to draw arms or provoke the enemy *I will cut down*. Is that clear?”

Quallet addressed the company, impressing on them the seriousness of the charge. Then he had them move out, slowly, the banners waving as he

approached the site of the battle.

His company was spotted instantly, of course. The [Generals] and [Commanders] of both sides kept sentries posted for attacks from every direction. In no time, a patrol of Centaurs was racing towards him.

Although suppression companies like Gravetender's Fist provided a service needed by all sides, Quallet had contracted with the Roving Arrow company, which was mainly Centaurs, although Quallet knew they'd probably hired smaller companies to supplement their forces.

He didn't get to meet with the company's [Commander]—in fact, he didn't meet with any officers. Quallet was instead directed to a neutral zone, away from the fighting and told brusquely that other suppression companies—those hired by the opposing side as well—were there.

This too was a standard practice in war. War vendors, [Merchants] who specialized in sales to an army during a conflict, as well as suppression companies and other independent parties often frequented battlefields. The custom was that there were areas untouched by the fighting, clearly marked as neutral zones where they stayed.

That was the custom. Although Quallet knew that sometimes such companies masqueraded as neutral and influenced a battle covertly—or overtly if they broke the rules of war. It was rare and such a company would be marked for all of time, but it did happen. He only prayed that this battle wouldn't see such an event occurring.

It wasn't likely. And everything seemed normal as Quallet found two other undead suppression companies waiting for nightfall in the space already allocated. Rot's Bane, a small group of experts and Untimely Demise, a large company full of green soldiers much like his own, were already set up in the best spot. Quallet directed Xor and Raeh to set up where they could as he met the two other company [Captains].

"Quallet Marshhand! I told you this would be a profitable battle!"

The first man to stride towards him was a bald fellow named Ulvial. He was in charge of Untimely Demise and wasn't as good a warrior or leader as Quallet—but he made do with a set of officers that stayed with him.

"Ulvial. Good to see you. Thanks for tipping me off about this battle."

Quallet clasped hands with him and nodded to the second [Captain]. She was a Centaur named Exara. He'd never worked with her directly, but he'd heard her small group was efficient and disciplined.

"A pleasure to work with you, Captain Exara."

"Pleased."

She trotted over to him and gripped his hand in a light handshake. Quallet looked around the open area they'd been assigned and noticed a group of Centaurs staring at them. All of them were armed and alert.

"Not your group, I take it."

Exara shook her head.

"Guards. They're watching my company since our contract was bought by the Razorblades."

"Huh."

That *was* odd. Normally suppression companies were trusted—they banked their ability to be hired on their reputations for honest work without bias. Quallet frowned, but reassured himself with the knowledge that he was on the same side as the Centaurs. He looked back at Ulvial.

"Your company looks quite large. Expecting a lot of undead to work with?"

"Yes indeed! Haven't you seen the battlefield? Both the Centaurs and Dullahans are carving each other up out there."

"What's the feud about?"

Exara and Ulvial shrugged at the same time. They didn't know, didn't need to know. They only had to do their jobs.

"Some land argument? Money? Someone hired them? Either way, we'll earn gold by the fistful for dealing with all the bodies."

"It'll be a chore between our companies."

Quallet was already calculating the ground they had to cover. The valley was big—he was used to such sizes, but they'd have to work in quadrants, possibly saving some areas for other days if they didn't have enough forces.

“Oh, we’ll be working into dawn each day. But we’ll be paid for it, and paid well! It’s simpler and easier than dying in this bloodbath, that’s for certain.”

Ulvial laughed and Quallet winced. Suppression companies were indeed paid well, mainly because they were doing fighting of their own, but regular companies resented the need for them. Large ones like the Great Companies made their soldiers do the work, and there wasn’t a regular soldier alive who didn’t resent a suppression company for staying out of the real danger.

Some of the Centaur guards were glaring. To change the subject, Quallet asked about a map and was shown to the one Exara and Ulvial had already carved up into portions. He studied it and tapped a spot as he conferred with the other two.

“We’ll take the west side and work our way in. I’ve a group of new recruits, most of which don’t know a sword from their own arm.”

They nodded, not bothered by the spot he’d chosen. It was off-center from the fighting, which meant Quallet would get fewer corpses to deal with. Each suppression company was paid by the amount of corpses they disposed of, by fire or sword.

“Fine by me. I’ll take the south, then.”

“And I’ll head in from the east. Just make sure to have your banners up and illuminate yourselves. The soldiers from both sides are on heavy night patrol and they’re jumpy.”

Exara warned the other two [Captains] and Quallet nodded seriously. The last thing he needed was to tangle with soldiers from either side and get somebody killed. Ulvial grunted in agreement.

“No fear. I’ve seen what happens to anyone who sticks their heads out of the neutral zones. The fighting’s everywhere. Speaking of which, have you heard there’s another independent group out there? Not just the war vendors—some kind of rogue unit!”

That got Quallet’s attention. Rogue detachments of soldiers were a wildcard. They could be a group of warriors or bandits or any number of things that entered the fray on one side or none at all. They were a danger to suppression companies if they attacked while they were working.

“Who or what is it?”

“Not a large group. Not a fighting force.”

Exara frowned as she tapped a neutral zone north of their position. She hesitated.

“I’ve heard it’s a unit that treats wounded soldiers.”

“Whose?”

“Any side’s. Apparently there’s a skilled [Doctor] working over there. She appeared when the battle started getting intense and offered her services. It’s caught the attention of both companies, and there’s a cease-fire in agreement in the area she works in.”

Curious and curiouser. Quallet’s brows snapped together. It was Ulvial who asked the obvious question.

“What’s so special about a [Doctor]? Both companies should have healing potions enough. It’s not like they lost their entire supply to raids like the Raverian Fighters.”

The mention of that company’s fate made both Exara and Quallet wince. The Raverian Fighters had barely survived their last engagement, as repeat attacks on their healing potion stashes—and attempts to resupply—had sent the company in full-blown retreat, barely a quarter of its strength.

Exara shook her head.

“I don’t know why she’s here, but apparently this [Doctor] can heal wounds without healing potions—and quickly, too! She’s apparently better than a [Healer] and with potions she can bring soldiers back when they’re considered dead by all.”

“A useful person to have around, then. I’ll watch out.”

Ulvial grunted and Quallet nodded. He doubted he’d need to use her services, but it was worth remembering.

Talk then turned to more practical matters, and soon Quallet was back at his camp.

“None of you are to stray beyond the neutral zone, or pick fights with other soldiers! You’ll be heading in to your first battle tonight. Yes, you’ll

be hauling bodies, but you'll see the undead, and without us to hold your hand this time!"

He needn't have warned his soldiers. They were staring at the battle between the Dullahans and Centaurs with wide eyes, even the ones who were used to fighting. Quallet only had to glance to his left to see distant shapes battling out in the valley below. There were Centaurs charging at armored shapes, arrows flying, magic breaking the ground, blood—

He looked away. There was no point in watching. But the new recruits had never seen such slaughter, and the Humans were transfixed.

"Dude. No way. This is *insane*."

Quallet heard one of them speaking and shook his head. This was Baleros. A continent where war was in the blood, just like how Rhir was constantly locked in struggle. And this wasn't one of the largest warzones. This was two companies fighting, not ten or a hundred.

Still, it was a war, and being so close to it made all of Quallet's senses sharp. He slept lightly until nightfall, knowing the new soldiers wouldn't get a wink. It didn't matter.

As night began, both sides began drawing back, avoiding skirmishing at night to avoid chaos, keep from sending their troops to fight a neutral party —

And to avoid losing them to the undead. Quallet eyed the sinking sun and saw the other companies readying themselves. He had his soldiers gear up, refreshed their memories about who was supposed to do what—

And waited.

Soon, there was no more fighting in the valley below. The darkness was extreme. The sounds of battle had ended, but now other sounds took their place. Animals calling out, insects—

And the screams of those left on the battlefield. There were wounded there, unable to be recovered or too injured to be saved with healing potions. Some of the Humans in Quallet's company paled from the sounds. Others threw up.

All normal. Quallet gritted his teeth as he saw Exara bring her small company down the slopes, a shining banner raised and illuminating their

forces. He ordered Xor to do the same and turned to his company.

Pale faces and frightened expressions stared up at him. Quallet saw most of the children who'd signed up to fight wavering. Of course they would. But here and there he saw determination like iron in their gazes, unflinching resolution at what had to be done.

The young man with black skin had that look. Strangely, so did the young man and woman, the two odd-looking ones standing next to him. They'd been petrified fighting the zombies, but now they had the look. It was the look that told Quallet they might survive this night.

It wasn't bravery or bravado. It wasn't the thrill of battle, but the will to survive. That was what they needed. Quallet looked into their eyes and then drew his axe. He pointed towards the valley below, where shapes were beginning to stand. To rise.

"Gravetender's Fist...*move out!*"

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1.03 D

There was a rite of passage among medical students, although it wasn't publicly talked about. And that was that in many graduate programs, regardless of whether you were studying to be a physician or just aimed to practice general medicine, it used to be mandatory to take a class in which you would dissect a human cadaver.

Geneva had known she'd have to open someone up when she'd first enrolled as a medical student. She'd dreaded the moment, feared the impartiality of it. Then had come the moment when she cut open the gray, lifeless body. It had felt solemn, and she remembered the classroom being hushed as the students around her felt themselves taking a step into a world many would never dream of entering.

They cut open a body, dissected it, identified organs, and within a few days, felt used to it. That was the point. No amount of illustrations in books or lectures could give you the hands-on experience of touching a real body, and that was what a surgeon or specialist needed most of all.

Experience.

Of course, now medical programs were cutting back on using human corpses, due to lack of time and the expense of obtaining ones for medical students to practice on. And yet, therein lay the irony of surgery, of Geneva's profession.

To become a great surgeon, one capable of taking on the hardest challenges, one had to practice. But no one trusted a new surgeon. And yet, a surgeon *had* to operate, and thus, make mistakes to grow experienced.

In short, it always came back to the same contradiction: a surgeon grew from the patients who died under her care.

It wasn't always like that of course. That was a harsh generalization. In another hospital, there would be veterans, older doctors, and other surgeons on standby who could help out in an emergency. But part of Geneva had wondered, idly, while she listened to her professors lecture, whether experience was all a doctor needed.

The average surgeon took on many operations each year. Hundreds. But they also followed a strict set of rules, having to clean themselves, create sterile operating environments—all to make sure their patients had the best chance possible.

In wars, medicine was not so nice. During the Second World War, doctors had to see to patients without the luxury of a schedule, or even a full team of trained helpers. Soldiers would come in all at once, sometimes by the hundreds, and it would force the helpless doctors and medics to make the hardest choices. They'd have to balance who would live and who would die, and who would be easier to save. They could save one life while ten more passed, or save ten and let the one die.

Perhaps those doctors had been the best. They would have operated countless times each day. Did that confer some sort of instinct? Some innate sense of the body and how to save it? Geneva had wondered about that as a student. Now—she knew. And the answer was simple, painful.

No. After a while, all the bodies began to look the same. The living—but especially the dead.

“Beginning the incision. Make sure the patient is still asleep and let me know if they wake up!”

Geneva snapped as she raised a scalpel and sliced into the wounded Dullahan's chest. The blade she was using delved past the shattered chest plate of the Dullahan's armor—a small mercy or she would have had to saw through it, taking precious time. Now Geneva cut into the thick skin that was the last layer of protection between the Dullahan's internal organs and the outside world.

The two [Soldiers] who stood in the tent nodded. They were used to the work, and both were ready to grab the Dullahan if he woke. They stared grimly at the broken and bleeding insides of the Dullahan, and then away. They'd volunteered for this, and respected Geneva for what she could do.

But few people could look at what a surgeon did to the body without flinching. Geneva's left hand was a blur as it cut, exposing a bloodied mess of organs beneath.

“Internal bleeding. I need a healing potion!”

Her right hand shot out and grabbed a bowl of liquid. Geneva carefully administered it, watching as the organs, muscles, and tissue that had been battered and torn by the mace slowly closed.

Healing potions. Faster and better than anything in her world. Geneva eyed the rest of the wounded site, and saw nothing wrong.

“Suturing.”

Her hands moved with experienced speed. Her left shot out and grabbed a curved needle, already threaded in preparation for this event. The other found a pair of forceps.

The [Soldiers] in the tent turned back to watch as Geneva began to sew up the Dullahan’s mended chest. This they could appreciate, and there was something miraculous about how fast Geneva moved. Her left hand was a blur as it stitched up the flesh of the Dullahan’s chest, closing the long incision in moments. Her right hand moved slower by comparison, carefully grasping the flesh and bringing it together to be sewn up.

And then it was done. Geneva stepped back from the closed flesh and grabbed the bowl of healing potion. She sprinkled a few drops of it over the stitches, and watched the wound heal.

Partially. That was all she could ration. Geneva put the bowl back and found the Dullahan’s shattered chest plate. She couldn’t fix his armor, but it was important to them that it stayed together.

“Wash this. Make sure you give him the lecture about keeping the wound clean.”

She spoke to one of the [Soldiers], another Dullahan with dull grey iron armor. She nodded and after locking her head into place on her shoulders, carried the Dullahan off of Geneva’s operating table and out of the room.

Done. Geneva sagged for a second, feeling the tension of the operation fade away. She spoke as the last [Soldier] filed out, but not to him.

“That was a relief. I thought a piece of the armor might have been stuck in his chest.”

There was no one there to hear that could be seen. But a voice replied, inaudible except in Geneva’s head. Because it was speaking *in* her head.

“If it had been, what would you have done?”

“Removed it. Hoped the healing potion solved the worst of the issues—sutured what I could. Time was of the essence, Okasha. If I had the ability to do blood transfusions, I’d have more time. But I haven’t been able to fix up a proper needle and pump mechanism.”

“I see. Should I see if there are any ways to construct such a thing later?”

Geneva shook her head slightly, speaking to the thing listening to her. *In* her. The Selphid named Okasha was in her body, controlling her right arm. She could probably feel the vibrations in Geneva’s vocal chords before the words left her mouth.

“Don’t bother. The healing potions replenish lost fluids, and they’re faster. It’s better to use them rather than try and maintain a blood bank, especially in this heat.”

Okasha didn’t reply, but Geneva felt an acknowledgement, a gentle *twitch* that ran through her body’s nervous system. It wasn’t unpleasant; the opposite, in fact. But it would have terrified her to experience such a thing, to know someone was sharing her body a few months ago.

Now she didn’t react. Geneva had long since made her peace with what had happened. Although there were things to get used to.

Like how her body would move. Geneva found herself walking over to a bench in the corner of her impromptu operating area, sitting down. She hadn’t intended any of it, but Okasha had taken over and Geneva hadn’t tried to fight. She wasn’t sure what would happen if she did, to be honest. Okasha had never brought the subject up. She was a friend, an assistant on the operating table, and she worried about Geneva. Too much, sometimes.

“You should rest. You’ve been awake for over a day now.”

Geneva knew that. She felt the exhaustion in her body, but she shook her head anyways.

“I’m fine, Okasha. I need to stay awake.”

“But if you don’t sleep—”

“I’ll sleep after this lot. I promise. Just give me a moment.”

Okasha fell silent. Geneva sighed, and lowered her head. The Dullahan would live. He wouldn't fight for a day at least—she'd keep him here in the field hospital she ran, until the convoy arrived at night to take him back to his army. Then, depending on whether they decided to treat him with more healing potions, he might be fighting tomorrow.

The living came to be saved, and then went back to kill or be killed the next day. Geneva had struggled with that knowledge, wondering if she was doing the right thing. She didn't know. She only knew that she had sworn an oath. If there was a life she could save, she did.

There was no one else who could. In Baleros, a continent that bled, Geneva was the only [Doctor]. The only true one, at any rate.

She wondered, sometimes, what those brave souls laboring to save lives had felt during the war. Did they fight for every life, clinging to it, fighting to fix the horrible things bullets and humans could do to each other? Or did the feeling of despair slowly sink in? Did the endless tide of bodies crush them?

She didn't know. She couldn't ask. Geneva sat quietly in the tent, hearing the sounds of battle in the distance, screams of the wounded around her. In a few moments the tent flap would open, and another wounded person would come in. Another life for her to fight for. But right now she just sat. She was tired, exhausted.

Geneva Scala, a Level 26 [Doctor], sat with Okasha humming a quiet melody in her ears, transmitting the song into Geneva's mind by projecting the sound directly into the inner ear. It was a soothing melody, and Geneva closed her eyes. If she slept for a minute, Okasha would make sure her body stayed upright.

She was so tired. She would have loved to rest, but there was always someone crying out. There was always a war. This was her third battlefield since coming to this world. Geneva had been working non-stop since then. Saving lives. Fighting.

She couldn't remember what it was like to smile.

Kenjiro Murata knew he was no hero. He was not a warrior, although he'd been in a few fights growing up. But he wasn't someone who liked to fight, and he preferred to defuse tense situations rather than escalate them.

That was Ken's problem. He *wasn't* many things. Some people were good at everything. Not Ken. He wasn't a top athlete although he liked running on the track. He'd never placed that high on exams, and if he was honest, he wasn't good-looking. Not that he had an unattractive face! But none of those attributes could define him in a meaningful way.

In truth, there was only one thing Ken was good at, and that was understanding other people. He liked meeting people. He liked talking to people he didn't know—especially foreigners.

It wasn't that he was that social, either. Ken would have agreed that he was no social butterfly—if he'd understood what that phrase meant in English. He just...liked other people. He liked other cultures, studying about other nations. He dreamed of travelling, which is why he had rejoiced at a chance to visit Australia as part of his university's foreign exchange program.

Ken wasn't that good at learning languages so he felt awkward, but he'd been excited to travel to Australia and talk with everyone he could. That was why he'd wanted to be a businessman, preferably someone who travelled abroad and negotiated business deals in foreign countries.

It was his big dream, the thing that Ken had aimed for ever since high school. He knew his grades weren't the best, but he'd persevered. He wasn't excellent at speaking English—he wasn't gifted, but he kept practicing. If he had a talent, Ken would have said he was good at observing people, learning how they acted.

This is what he saw.

“Zombie!”

It came towards him, making a horrible scratchy sound through its damaged vocal chords. It was a zombie, the weakest of the undead. But it was also a Centaur, and so it was terrifying for other reasons.

“Get around it!”

Someone shouted. Luan ran past Ken and bashed the Centaur's back left leg. It stumbled, and Ken dodged away from its swinging arms. The Centaur, tall as any horse—taller, in fact since it had the human torso on top—twisted, and the dead female's head focused on Luan.

“Now!”

Ken heard the call and he ran forwards at the same time three others did. He cut at the Centaur's side as Aiko speared it from one end and two Dullahans cut at it with swords. Luan ran forwards and delivered the final strike—a hammer blow to the Centaur's head. He alone was tall enough to hit her there, and the Centaur, body too broken to move, finally fell.

Ken backed away, shaking, sweaty. He waited for the Centaur to move as Aiko pulled her spear back and stabbed it in the head, but it didn't. It was finally dead. He breathed out and heard a voice.

“Everyone okay? Hey, you two good? Ken?”

Luan was walking around, checking on everyone. As leader of their small group, one patrol of the Gravetender's Fist company, he felt the need to make sure they were well. Ken raised a shaking hand and gave him a thumbs up.

“Good work, mate.”

Luan raised his fist and Ken turned his gesture into a weak fist-bump. The tall South African man grinned at him and turned to the Dullahans.

“You two good?”

They were. Everyone was good, even Aiko. She stepped away from the corpse as Luan turned to it. Ken heard him groan.

“Now we've got to drag this back to the pile. Damn it. We should have lured her closer.”

He gestured, and the five gathered around the Centaur. Grimly, each one reached down and began to haul the body away. It was horrible. Ken and the other Humans had gloves and the Dullahans had gauntleted hands, part of the armor that covered their entire body, but the stench and smell was overpowering.

Not to mention the Centaur wasn't entirely whole. A part of her fell off as she was being dragged—Ken looked away and tried not to gag.

Perhaps it would have been easier if they cut her up and carried the bits to one of the corpse piles that would be burned come dawn. But neither Ken nor the other new recruits in Gravetender's Fist had the stomach for it. So they dragged the body, swearing as they crossed the uneven ground and mud, heading towards a place where a pair of armed soldiers with lanterns stood looking in every direction.

"Hey there!"

"Hey! It's us!"

Luan called out as the two soldiers spotted their group. He didn't need to say anything else. He just needed to reassure the soldiers that they were alive and not undead. The lantern that Aiko carried helped, but Ken had learned to be wary of every moving shape as they worked.

Their group deposited the corpse at the pile of bodies. It stank. Flies buzzed and Ken had to back away fast or vomit again. Not that his stomach was full—he'd been told not to eat anything before nightfall, and this was why.

"Big one."

One of the soldiers commented and Luan grimaced.

"She got up right when we came by. Scared us all to death."

"Be grateful she wasn't a Ghoul. Only thing worse than a Centaur Ghoul is a Dullahan one."

The soldiers called out as Luan and the group trudged away. Ken glanced at the two Dullahans, one male, one female, but neither reacted to the statement. Probably because it was fact. A Zombie Dullahan was a nightmare to fight, mainly because of their armor and the fact that their head might be lying on the ground, making putting them down again that much harder. You had to batter them to pieces unless you found the head.

"Let's go back. It's this way, I think. Right, Aiko?"

"Yes."

Their group trudged back the way they'd come. They had an area to cover, and the zombie Centaur was only one of the bodies they had to haul back to the pile to be burned. It was a horrible, foul job, and Ken hated it. But he had signed up and so he had to work.

This was Gravetender's Fist. A suppression company enlisted to dispose of the undead and corpses that were the natural byproduct of a conflict involving two companies, the Razorshard Armor company, and the Roving Arrow company.

Ken's unit, along with everyone else in the company, had a simple job. They went out, found dead bodies, collected them into a pile, and burned them so undead wouldn't spawn from them. They killed any undead that had already risen, and then got off the battlefield before the two sides began fighting again.

This was their third night doing it. Was it better the third time?

Yes. A bit. The third night was better than the first, if only because there was no shock and horror. The fear was still there, almost overwhelming the senses in the torch-lit darkness, but Ken and the others could operate under it now.

"Body pile!"

Aiko called out to her left and Ken, Luan, and the two Dullahans stopped dead in their tracks. They moved towards Aiko and spotted a group of corpses. They approached warily, weapons at the ready. A pile of bodies could be burying a zombie or something worse. Aiko stepped forwards and stabbed the pile repeatedly, but nothing moved.

"Let's take them back."

Luan sighed and Ken reached down to tug at the armor of one fallen soldier. He paused as he saw a Human face in the lantern light, twisted with fear. It was staring right at him.

"Ken?"

Aiko's voice snapped Ken's head up. He saw her looking at him. He shook his head.

"Nothing."

He began to pull at one leg, as Aiko gingerly took an arm. They dragged the body away and Luan bent.

“Hold up. The sword’s here.”

He pulled it away before Ken and Aiko dragged the body any further. Luan went around collecting armor, weapons that could be used, while the Dullahans dragged one body. Ken and Aiko resumed pulling their burden.

Back towards the pile. It was most efficient that way, apparently. Burning each body where it had fallen was too hard, and it carried a risk of spreading fire. So the Gravetender’s Fist company had designated areas where piles of corpses were collected, to be disposed of later.

The pile Ken and the others were assigned to was taller than he was, and it was one of many. It took hundreds of people hours of non-stop work to collect the bodies and burn them before the next day began. It felt meaningless because the next day the soldiers would begin slaughtering each other as soon as it was light, but the work was necessary.

Bad things appeared if the bodies weren’t laid to rest. Ken saw one of those things later that night. He heard a scream that rose above the buzzing of insects, the voices in the distance, and the pounding of his heart.

“Ghoul!”

He and the others froze in place. Ghoul. One of the stronger, faster variants of undead. They were rarer, but far deadlier than a zombie. And the call had come from nearby.

“What should we do?”

One of the Dullahans looked around, her hands tight on her sword hilt. She was wide-eyed. She’d seen a Ghoul before, seen what they could do. Ken’s stomach twisted with fear. He’d seen too.

Luan’s voice was steady. He motioned them to stand in a circle, as they’d been instructed to do.

“Stay together. Watch for anything—”

“Look! The Captain!”

Aiko cried out. Ken saw their company’s captain, Quallet Marshhand, sprinting in the direction of the scream. He shouted, and Ken saw a blur of

movement heading towards him. Quallet slashed out at it with his axe, incredibly fast. For a moment his form was obscured, and then Ken and the others saw him hacking at something on the ground. The chaos ended.

The Ghoul was dead.

“Back to work!”

Quallet shouted at all of the people who’d stopped, his voice reaching far across the valley. Ken felt a hand on his shoulder and Luan nodded.

“You heard him. More corpses.”

That was life. Ken slowly began to move forwards, shoulders aching, sweat and insects fighting for space on his body. He kept dragging bodies towards the pile until he heard a horn call, and hurried back towards the gleaming flag, illuminated by magic and lighting up the area around it. As the sun broke over the hills around the valley, Quallet led his weary company back towards the neutral ground where they could rest and sleep.

Another day done. Countless more to come.

When he wasn’t on duty, which lasted the whole night, Ken slept. He woke up past midday like the others, found food waiting for him, and ate the unpalatable rations in silence. Then he glanced at the sun.

It was falling fast due to the season being allegedly winter. Ken had already learned to hate that fact: it meant he had to work more and night would come sooner. But for a few precious hours, he was free to stay within the neutral zone his company had been allotted. He could chat with other members of Gravetender’s Fist or the other suppression companies, scrub himself with dirt—water being far too precious, unless it rained—gamble for food with dice, squat in a latrine if he needed to relieve himself, or go back to sleep.

Small things. But Ken would have gladly squatted over the insect-covered pits in the ground for hours rather than spend five minutes hauling corpses. Well, maybe an hour for every ten minutes.

Instead of going over to where the people from his world, the Humans of various nationalities, mostly American, Australian, and European countries, were talking and sitting amongst themselves (or having sex in one of the tents, which had bothered Ken and Aiko when they'd heard about it—and heard it happening), Ken took a chance and went over to talk with another group that sat by a fire, talking amongst themselves.

The Lizardfolk, one of the main races inhabiting Baleros, looked up as one as Ken approached. He smiled and waved at them, which was received well, because they instantly waved him over.

“Human! Do you need something? Is it orders from Captain Marshhand?”

Some called out to Ken as he hesitantly sat by the fire, trying to smile, to project sociability. To Ken's knowledge, this was the first time anyone from his group had tried sitting with the Lizardfolk. They'd chatted of course, but never for long. It had always been—what was the word? Awkward.

And Ken had an idea why.

“No I am not here with orders. I would just like to ah, talk.”

“Talk!”

Some of the Lizardfolk immediately laughed and crowded around Ken, in a moment he found himself sitting by lots of scaly bodies. The Lizardfolk of Baleros were thin and reptilian, with long tails and colorful neck frills of flesh. They looked like they had odd versions of a lion's mane—each Lizardfolk had a very colorful frill, which often contrasted with the rest of their scales.

“So why do you want to talk to us, Human? What is your name?”

Ken found himself looking at a blue-scaled Lizardgirl with deep red neck frills, bordering on purple. He knew her.

“You are Quexa, yes? I am Kenjiro Murata. I am very pleased to meet you.”

“Oh! You were assigned to my pile last night! Did you hear about the Ghoul? It attacked my group—nearly got me!”

Quexa grinned at him, her red neck frills opening and closing as she gestured to some other Lizardfolk.

“I thought I was going to die—I tried to hit it with magic, but it was too fast! Then Captain Quallet came and cut its head open! Lucky! You look different from the other Humans, you and that girl. Are you two having sex?”

Ken’s eyes widened and he tried to reply to Quexa in order. Lizardfolk had an odd way of talking. They’d ask and reply to multiple questions and statements in the same sentence. To fit in, Ken tried to do the same.

“I am very glad you are okay. I ah, am from Japan. It is a different country, so I look different. I and Aiko are *not* having sex.”

Quexa’s eyes brightened in appreciation and Ken saw other Lizardfolk nodding as they listened to his scatter-shot response. He smiled inwardly. Yes, this was how you talked to Lizardfolk! He was right! The mood around him grew more intimate and Quexa scooted closer, a sure sign he was being accepted.

“Oh, I was asking because you look the same. And a lot of you are having sex! Every *day* you Humans have sex! Aren’t you worried about getting pregnant? Or do you all have birth charms? Can we borrow them? They must be very effective!”

“I uh, do not now about birth charms. Many of my...my friends are very worried, so they have sex. I uh, do not know about being pregnant. I hope they do not become pregnant, because we have no charms.”

“What?”

“Humans are so reckless!”

“Are you interested in trying it with us?”

The Lizardfolk practically jumped on Ken, asking questions, laughing, speaking in a jumble with no clear leader. As was their way. Ken had watched them carefully before this moment, and he thought he understood Lizardfolk. He had observed how they interacted. So they could understand him. So he could understand them. So they could be...friends?

The first thing Kenjiro had observed was that of the three non-Human species in Gravetender’s Fist, the Lizardfolk liked to talk the most. In fact,

they were what he would call おしゃべり, or ‘chatterboxes’ as some of the Americans called them. Only, that applied to their entire species, not just one in particular.

It wasn’t hard to observe the other races—Ken had served with them for three days already, on top of the time he’d been marching with them. And one thing Ken had noticed was that Lizardfolk stuck together. They liked being part of a group and, this was crucial, seemed to decide things en-masse.

They were also uncomfortable being the odd ones out, which is why Ken had noticed that every time a group of people from his world came over to talk to a few, the Lizardfolk had seemed edgy. It was only when they were in greater numbers than the outsiders that they seemed happy to talk.

They didn’t like being outnumbered. But when they weren’t, they were as social as could be, which is why Ken had chosen to speak with them, rather than Dullahans or Centaurs first. He wanted to, well, he just wanted to be friendly with them.

Ken *believed* in being friends, in forging relationships. It was a part of his culture—making strong ties and getting to know people was how the business world in Japan worked. It was everything, and Ken was trying to apply that idea here. It was all he knew, and they were all on the same side, right? All the more reason to be friends. Especially because Ken knew nothing of this world.

And Lizardfolk *liked* to talk.

“You’ve never met a Lizardperson? Ever?”

Quexa had moved rapidly past the horribly awkward and intimate talk of sex and was quizzing Ken about where he had come from. He couldn’t answer concretely, but she seemed happy enough to explain her people to him.

“We’re Lizardpeople! Only, you knew that. We’re the biggest species on Baleros—there’s Dullahans and Centaurs of course, but we have more sex than they do. We’re *sort* of like Drakes, if you’ve met Drakes, although they hate it when we say that. We’re not related, you know, although we look sort of the same.”

“Ah, yes. I know Dullahans and Centaurs. But there are other species, yes?”

“Yes!”

Quexa laughed at Ken and the other Lizardfolk immediately shouted out names of species.

“Ever seen a Selphid?”

“What about a Fraerling? Ever stepped on one?”

“How about a Gazer?”

“Seen a Naga? One of our people?”

Ken hadn't. Quexa pointed a Selphid out for him, and he saw one of the pale-white soldiers standing in the Untimely Demise company, talking with a Centaur. The Selphid had a Lizardperson's body, but the body was clearly...dead. The scales were pale, and there was a bloodless wound on the side of the Lizardperson's body that wasn't bleeding. Ken shivered and Quexa noticed.

“Don't worry! Selphids don't steal living bodies. Or they're not supposed to. They did that in the past, you know? Only, now if they do it we kill them. So they steal corpses! They live inside them. That's a Selphid. I'd show you a Gazer, but I don't think you'd see many in a Centaur-led army or a Dullahan one. They keep to themselves, mainly.”

The conversation diverged into a lecture about how weird Selphids were, with other Lizardfolk adding in details and stories.

“You know they never fight? Selphids. Even if they're hired on opposite sides, if they meet they just bow to each other and won't do battle, no matter what! I think that's because there are so few. Well, we killed a lot of them a long time ago.”

“Hey, are any of your people [Mages]? You have a lot of shining magical artifacts. We see them, though you keep hiding them! What do they do?”

Pressured by the Lizardfolk, Ken tried to explain about the iPhones, computers, tablets, and other electronic devices some of the Humans from his world had carried. He showed his dead iPhone to the Lizardfolk and

they were all over it, poking and prodding and vocally disappointed when it didn't work.

Quexa handed the iPhone back to Ken. It had been dead ever since he'd come to Baleros—he'd forgotten to charge it and had been looking for a charger back in the Australian airport when he'd been taken. Aiko didn't have hers, and neither did Luan.

"You should get that fixed! I bet a [Repair] spell would do it. I'd cast it, but I don't know the spell."

"Ah. And you are a [Mage]?"

She shook her head.

"I'm a [Sorcerer]. It's not the same as the [Mage] class, you know. We cast magic by *thinking* about it real hard. Mages learn spells, but us [Sorcerers] are too lazy. We can't use big spells unless we're really high-level, but we don't have to study. Cool, right?"

"Yes, very!"

Ken tried to be as friendly as possible. After an hour of rapid-talk his head was spinning, so he got up and politely excused himself.

"I am very glad to meet you all. I hope we can talk soon, and that you are all safe this night. Thank you very much for greeting me."

He bowed to them, making the Lizardfolk cry out farewells and warmly wave him off. Satisfied, Ken left the group and heard them continue chattering behind his back.

"See? I told you some of them were nice."

"Did you hear his accent? I wonder where he's from."

"What about the shining things? You didn't ask where they got them—"

Ken made his way back to the Humans and explained to Luan and Aiko what he'd done. The other Humans clustered around him, and soon they were going over to the Lizardfolk—in smaller groups. Chatter started up, and soon the Lizardpeople were comfortable enough to talk with Humans on their own. Ken felt accomplished, and then felt his happiness drain away as the sun set.

The valley was filled with bodies as Quallet ordered everyone to take up arms and march down into the darkness. He carried the flag of Gravitender's Fist, a fist shooting out of soil emblazoned on cloth that shone brightly in the dark. It was one of the precautions the suppression companies took. They carried bright lights and waved shining banners so neither army would look at them as enemies.

That was the fourth night.

On the fifth day, there was beer. Ken heard about it as soon as he woke up, and found a mug filled with a frothy orange liquid shoved into his hands by one of the Americans.

His name was Johanas. He explained to Ken, face flushed, already clearly intoxicated. Ken leaned back a bit as Johanas excitedly talked.

"One of the guys traded a flashlight to him for a ton of beer! Hey, did you know that you can recharge all of our stuff with magic? It turns out if you cast [Repair] on something, the batteries get recharged too!"

He looked very happy at the news. Ken was happy too—but reservedly so. He appreciated drinking as much as anyone else, but not, it seemed, as much as the Americans. Some were under twenty one, which was apparently the drinking age in America. So many of the young men and women from America were drinking a lot—too much, in Ken's opinion, to actually enjoy the experience.

Some were already throwing up.

"Thank you for telling me. Where did you buy the—beer—though?"

Ken stared at the orange liquid. It wasn't like any beer he'd ever seen, but apparently it was a popular drink in Baleros. Johanas pointed north, towards another group sharing the neutral zone.

"See those guys? The [Merchants]? They're...what, war vendors? Yeah, that's what they're called. They'll sell to anyone for the right price."

Ken did indeed know about the war vendors, opportunistic [Merchants] who travelled with heavy escorts to battlefields to supply armies in need of extra potions, arms, magical artifacts, and so on. And apparently, beer as well.

He spotted one of the [Merchants], and saw to his surprise a serpentine form, a good seven feet high, glittering gold and red scales that ran from a long and powerful tail up into a humanoid torso with two arms and a serpentine head. The Naga had long fins on the back of his head, like a Lizardperson's frills. And that was because...

Ken stared hard at the [Merchant], enough so that both he and Johanas noticed. The Naga turned, saw Ken looking, and waved at him. Ken kept staring.

"Dude, don't stare."

Johanas tugged him away, but Ken shook his head. He deliberately scrutinized the Naga from shining head to toe, noting how the Naga wore clothes only on his upper half, leaving his serpentine lower body free. He was *very* flashy, and his scales and clothing shone. He had small jewels embedded in the fabric!

"Hey, he's looking *at us*."

The slightly drunk and sobering Johanas looked worried, but Ken was not. Another aspect of Lizardfolk culture went into his staring.

"I think they do not mind. How can I say...? They like to be acknowledged."

"What?"

The other young man gave Ken a skeptical look, but Ken's theory was proven true in a few moments. Far from taking offense at Ken's obvious study of his body, the Naga instead grinned. He twisted his body around, showing off his serpentine features much to the approval of the Lizardfolk watching him.

"He is one of the Lizardfolk, I think."

"What? *Him*? But he looks nothing like them!"

Johanas was astonished. Ken nodded hesitantly.

“That is what they said. I think they turn into him. Into Nagas. Sometimes.”

The American young man stared at him. Ken turned his attention away from the Naga and shrugged. Johanas turned his head and then shook it, looking disoriented.

“Weird as fuck, man. I’ll, uh, I’ll see if the Lizards want to party, then. We have a *lot* of booze.”

So saying, he went over to the Lizardpeople. They were instantly on their feet and headed towards the place where the Americans were drinking, and Ken saw Johanas approach a group of Dullahans next.

Watch. Ken’s eyes narrowed slightly and he forgot the mug in his hands as he watched Johanas approach a group of five Dullahans. They had been talking quietly amongst themselves, but went silent as Johanas came over.

This is what Ken noticed. Of the five Dullahans, three had wooden armor, crude, seemingly hewn from trees. The other two though had metal armor. One looked like iron plate, the other, a type of scale mail. The other Dullahans seemed to defer to them.

It was about the armor. Ken was no expert, but the Dullahan with scale mail armor probably had the more expensive equipment, or body, than the one with iron armor. And that mattered. He watched as Johanas stumbled over and heard the young man’s voice.

“Hey, any of you lot want to drink? We’ve got free beer!”

He didn’t address the Dullahan in scale armor, nor the one with iron armor. And Ken knew immediately that was a mistake. The Dullahan in scale armor narrowed her eyes, and the Dullahan that Johanas had addressed, a wide-eyed, very young male in cheap wood armor, looked at her first before silently shaking his head.

“What about you then? Want to hang out?”

Ken winced as Johanas only now addressed the Dullahan in scale armor. She froze up. She looked irritated, furrowing her brows slightly. Johanas didn’t notice—Dullahan features changed only slightly and he was too drunk to see. She replied curtly and he stumbled away, shrugging.

The entire group of Dullahans had declined as one. None of them would go drink with the Americans, although a few Centaurs did drift over for the alcohol.

Ken was looking at the Lizardfolk, whom some of the Americans were unsuccessfully trying to convince to play a game of spin the bottle with, when someone spoke his name.

“Ken, what are you doing?”

He turned as Aiko approached him, speaking in Japanese. Ken pointed to the Lizardfolk, who were all refusing to play spin the bottle.

“They move as one group, you see, Aiko? If you cannot convince them as a whole, none will agree.”

Aiko eyed the group of Lizardfolk and shook her head.

“So? I think you spend too much time looking at them. Especially the female ones. What about Humans? We’re normal. They’re odd.”

Ken felt nettled by the comment. He turned away from Aiko, annoyed. He was trying to understand the other species. They were all in the same company—so what if Lizardpeople looked strange? So what if Dullahans could take their heads off, and Centaurs were half-horse, half-Human? He knew some of the people from his world couldn’t interact with the other species—he noted a girl refusing to go near one of the friendly Lizardfolk. But that wasn’t right.

“So what if they are different? We should get to know them better.”

He spoke sharply to Aiko. She stomped her foot, exasperated.

“We should stick together and work with other people from our world! They are talking each day, and you do not listen!”

A lot of the Americans were arguing it out with the Europeans and Australians, Ken knew. Everyone had been appalled at finding out just how horrible their duties were, and it was the Americans especially who wanted a change. But what could they do? He glared at Aiko.

“Should I go back and spend more time looking at Luan-san, then?”

Her face went red. Ken knew that Aiko had developed a crush on Luan. The South African man was older than everyone else, and he was always

optimistic, always taking command. She punched his shoulder and Ken yelped and moved away.

“*Idiot.*”

She stormed off. Ken turned back, feeling guilty, and stared at the Centaurs and how they were interacting with the very drunk Americans. He had a theory about them as well, but he was interrupted by Luan.

“Hey Ken, I saw you and Aiko talking. Did you have a fight?”

Ken turned and smiled at Luan. His friend had a mug in one hand as well and was sipping gingerly at it. He made a face as he came to sit by Ken.

“You two in an argument? She looked pretty upset. What was it about?”

Of all the people to ask—no, Luan was the one who kept Aiko and Ken company, who looked out for them. Of course he’d ask. But Ken could say nothing. He bit his lip and tried to respond.

“I ah, how do I say this? I do not think I can tell you. It is not my secret to give away. I am sorry.”

“Don’t worry about it.”

Luan grinned at him, and then frowned at his mug.

“Have you tasted this? It’s awful.”

“No.”

Ken sipped at his drink and recoiled at the taste. The liquid was *sour* in a very unpleasant way. The Americans didn’t seem to mind the taste, but as Luan observed, they were only trying to get drunk.

“Half of them aren’t allowed to drink in their country. Crazy.”

Ken nodded in agreement. The drinking age in Japan was 20 years, but it wasn’t enforced in any strict sense of the word. In South Africa, it was apparently 18. That only mattered because Ken and Luan had had the chance to drink quite a few times before now. For Americans, it was apparently a lot harder.

“They are enjoying themselves. I am told they traded a flashlight for beer.”

Luan had heard that, and he wasn't happy about it. He frowned as he took another sip of his drink and nearly spat it back out.

"They shouldn't have done that. It was a bad idea."

"Why?"

Ken saw Luan hesitate, and then glance around. No one was nearby to listen—they were either drinking, or trying to ignore the shouting coming from the people who were drinking. Still, Luan lowered his voice.

"That flashlight is very valuable. We don't have a way to get more, and if we can repair it with magic, it's too valuable to waste. But those assholes didn't listen to me, or any of the Germans. They're playing by their own rules and no one else's opinion matters."

"Damn right they are. Fucking bastards."

Both Ken and Luan jumped. Someone had snuck up behind them. Someone with a class in [Rogue], which he'd gotten from sneaking around the battlefield. A tanned young man with blonde hair and a sword. His name was Daly, and he was from Australia. He put a hand on both Ken and Luan's shoulders and he leaned in with them.

"You lot talking about the Americans, right? Know anything?"

"Not a thing, mate."

Luan nodded familiarly with Daly. Perhaps it was because both of them said 'mate' that they got along. Or that they came from hot continents. Or... they just got along. Ken gently edged away from Daly. Intimate contact wasn't exactly something he was at home with.

"Those wankers are up to something, and they won't tell the rest of us what. You heard anything, uh...what're your names?"

"I'm Luan, this is Ken."

"Pleased to meet ya. Thought I'd seen you around, but couldn't remember your names off the top of my head."

Ken was treated to a firm handshake. Daly squatted down next to them and began to grouse about the American problem with Luan.

“We’re all on the same boat, right? Why the hell are they keeping things secret?”

Luan shook his head as Ken sipped his drink and kept tactfully silent.

“Americans. I think they want to tell us what to do.”

“Yeah, well, since none of them have a nuke shoved down their trousers, I’ll pass on that. We’re in it together and unless they tell us what they’re planning, none of our lot is budging. The work we’re doing is shite, but at least none of us are dying.”

Daly nodded at the group of Australians he was with. There was an even ratio of males and females there, and they were having a conversation with some of the Centaurs, shouting to be heard above the party which was now enveloping all three companies. Gravetender’s Fist, Rot’s Bane, and Untimely Demise. Ken wondered if one of the officers would break up the mayhem, until he saw officer Raeh drinking along with the rest of them.

“Right well, it was good to meet both of ya. I’d love to have a pint with you, but those damned idiots are hogging it all.”

The Australian young man stood up with a groan, and then went off to get something to drink as well. Ken heard him shouting as he approached the group of Americans, who were now singing their national anthem.

“Oi! Stop hogging all the alcohol! Share some, you buggers!”

Someone waved at Daly and he gave them a ‘V’ sign with his fingers that Ken was fairly sure didn’t stand for ‘victory’. Luan laughed as he watched a group of Centaurs finally come over to shout at the partying soldiers to shut up.

Ken turned back to Luan. He hesitated, not knowing where to begin.

“Good friend Luan-san...”

“Call me Luan, yeah?”

“Luan—I have been talking with the others. Lizardfolk, and I was thinking of doing so with the Dullahans and Centaurs, only Aiko does not think it is a good idea.”

He was on familiar enough terms now to call Aiko by her first name, and he was glad that Luan felt he was a friend. Ken certainly considered

him one. Luan nodded.

“Talking with them? Sounds good. I can’t get them to talk to me, but you got those Lizardfolk to open up. What’s Aiko’s problem?”

“I think she feels awkward. It is...they are very different, but I think they are like us. Some of the people from our world do not think so. But I—I think they are like us. What do you think?”

Ken held his breath, but Luan just smiled. He tapped his chest as he looked Ken in the eye.

“I was born during Apartheid, good friend Ken. I know about judging people by their skin. I think I should talk with Aiko, and you—should talk with the other species. We *are* all soldiers, yeah?”

“Yeah.”

Relieved, Ken grinned at Luan. That was how he found himself heading towards the group of Dullahans that Johanas had failed to invite. They were watching the partying with stony faces, and all of them stared flatly at Ken as he hesitantly approached.

This was different from the Lizardpeople. Ken braced himself. Where the species of Lizardfolk as a whole were cautious but quite open to talk, Dullahans were private. Notably so. They *didn’t* try to start conversations with people of other species unless it was out of necessity. But Ken thought the real barrier that none of the Humans had understood was the need for formality.

Americans weren’t formal. Europeans and people from Luan’s country...well, Ken didn’t actually know enough about each culture to be sure, but he knew that *Japanese* culture was very formal. Using the proper honorifics was extremely important in Japan, and it was something people from other countries had little grasp of.

It was like how in English, no one called him Murata-san or Ken-san, which would be more polite. It was all first names, which Ken found awkward at first. But Dullahans...they were slightly Japanese in the way they behaved towards one another.

This is what Ken had seen, from Johanas’ interactions with the Dullahans and other times. Dullahans had a hierarchy in any group, even if

it was just between two of them. It was unspoken, but it was there and it shaped every interaction they had. And it was all based on armor.

Every Dullahan had armor. But the type of armor, quality, and materials differed on each Dullahan. It was like clothing, only more intimate. It was a reflection of their personality and, Ken now understood, their social standing.

In a group, the Dullahans with the most impressive armor *always* spoke first, and everyone else deferred to them. It wasn't just what their armor was made of either; someone with ornate armor was more important than someone with the same material of armor, but less craftsmanship. You had to have an eye for it, but Ken was confident in this case.

He approached the group of five Dullahans as they stared at him warily. They clearly didn't want to talk, but Ken intended to prove he could show proper respect. That was why he didn't immediately speak to the closest Dullahan, but rather, to the one with scale armor, the one Johanas had failed to immediately address.

"Please excuse my rude interruption, but I was hoping I could speak with you all."

The Dullahan woman wearing scale armor blinked as Ken bowed his head towards her. She had placed her head next to her body, and now she grabbed her head and aimed her face at Ken to speak. She hesitated, and then replied.

"What do you wish to say, Human?"

The others looked from her to Ken as he introduced himself.

"I am Kenjiro Murata. I would like to introduce myself to fellow soldiers. May I ask your name?"

Again, he spoke directly towards the Dullahan in scale armor. She nodded after a moment.

"I am Eretta Fulvrie. I greet you, Kenjiro."

She spoke his name somewhat awkwardly, but Ken pretended not to notice. He nodded towards her and she nodded back. Then Ken turned to look at the Dullahan sitting across from her, the one in iron armor.

There was a flicker of surprise as the Dullahans noticed Ken's action. The Dullahan in iron armor glanced at Etretta. There was a flicker of approval in her eyes as she nodded slightly at him.

He introduced himself in a gravelly voice. He was named Lethic, and the other three Dullahans introduced themselves, in the order of the quality of their armor, not where they were sitting or their age. Kenjiro hid a smile. He was right!

"What is it you have come to say, Kenjiro Murata?"

"I wish to apologize for my comrade. He does not understand your culture, and he may have offended you. For that I am very sorry."

Ken spoke to Etretta, and the group at large. He bowed first to Etretta, and then to Lethic. The Dullahans stirred, murmured quietly. Etretta's eyes were sharp on Ken. She had a very fine sword and she, unlike the others, was an experienced soldier in Gravetender's Fist.

"Humans often make mistakes. We are used to it. But you think you understand our ways, Kenjiro?"

"I would not say I understand, but I hope to know more. Your people are a very impressive one."

Ken met Etretta's eyes for only a moment before looking away. He had a sense that staring at a Dullahan's head was too intimate. By contrast, staring at their armor was a sign of respect.

Again, his intuition paid off. Etretta cradled her head, growing visibly more relaxed as she and the others rested their heads on the ground or their laps, not holding them stiffly as they did around strangers. Was it a sign that they didn't think they were in danger?

"I accept your apology, Kenjiro. I would speak with you more if you are willing. Are there still drinks to be had?"

Kenjiro smiled. And after a second, so did Etretta. As it turned out there was still alcohol to be had, although they had to pass by several comatose bodies to get to it.

That night, Quallet swore a blue streak and threatened to thrash anyone too drunk to do their duty awake. It was up to Ken and the other Humans to get the people who'd literally passed out while drinking up and somewhat

sober. More than one person was stumbling as they headed out into the night.

The work was still desperate, still dirty, and this time, Kenjiro slipped while carrying a Dullahan's corpse and found a pile of maggots squirming down his armor. He lost what food he'd eaten, but it was a Dullahan, Lethic, who pulled him up. Quexa burned the maggots off the front of his armor as Luan and Aiko helped get the rest out from under his armor.

Small things. Kenjiro stumbled back into camp too tired to walk properly and reeking of filth. As his head hit the ground he heard a voice in his head. It had a surprise for him.

[Warrior Level 4!]

[Negotiator Class Obtained!]

[Negotiator Level 2!]

[Skill – Amateur Linguist obtained!]

[Skill – Polite Demeanor obtained!]

On the sixth day, Ken watched the fighting. He couldn't help it. Sometimes he could ignore it, when he was talking with people, watching the different species interact, but other times it was too raw, too visible to ignore.

Each day, the Razorshard Armor company and the Roving Arrow company lined up their forces and sent them into the valley to fight. It wasn't just like two masses of soldiers charging at each other, though. Both sides kept forces hidden in the trees, or moving around the outsides, clashing, trying to strike the enemy from behind.

Flights of arrows flew from the galloping Centaurs, and they charged into the armored Dullahans with lances and spears that pierced through their

heavy armor. The Dullahans brought forth a group of [Mages] that blasted groups of warriors apart until a Centaur charge forced them to fall back as the furious Centaur warriors hacked apart a group of Lizardfolk assigned to guard the [Mages].

It was terrible to watch. Terrible, and yet some part of the fighting called to Ken. Not the blood. Not the limbs and hacked open flesh, but the moments of heroism. They still shook his heart. He saw a [Soldier] hold off three Centaurs with a Skill that made his blade dance and create a whirlwind of metal that held the warriors off until his comrades could join him. He saw a [Mage] raise an emerald shield up and calmly walk through a hail of arrows.

That was the glorious, magical part of the battle. But it was savage and merciless too.

A group of Centaurs had roped a Dullahan commander and were dragging him across the battlefield, howling war cries as the soldiers tried to free their leader. They kept dragging the Dullahan across the broken ground long after he'd stopped moving. When they cut him loose, the Dullahan's corpse lay there. Ken saw the red streak it had left and turned away.

"Bloody horrific, ain't it?"

Someone joined Ken as he watched the Centaurs regrouping for another charge. He saw Daly and another Australian girl standing at the edge of the neutral zone and staring down at the carnage. Daly nodded to the young woman.

"This is Paige. Paige, this here is Ken."

"Pleased."

Paige offered her hand and Ken shook it lightly. She stared down at the battlefield, face grim. She didn't flinch away, though. Everyone from Aiko to Luan had gotten used to far worse, roaming the battlefield at night.

"They line up on the battlefield like gentlemen, and then start tearing each other to bits each morning. What kind of place is this?"

"Better than if they fought at night, too."

Daly shrugged, but Paige frowned.

“I heard someone got killed over by where the Untimely Demise lot were working. Not from an undead—they got shot.”

“By who?”

Both Ken and Daly looked at her in alarm. Paige didn’t know.

“I heard the Captain was asking about it. But I didn’t hear if he got an answer.”

Ken stared down at the valley, where Dullahans were marching towards the Centaurs, driving them back. It was incredible that after each day there were enough soldiers to keep fighting, but apparently both companies were sending their forces into the valley, rather than keep fighting and destroy the landscape around them. They were trying to wear each other down, rather than risk mutual destruction.

“So they’re just gonna keep tearing each other apart until one side starts winning? Sounds like the dumbest war in the world.”

“Sounds like *every* war.”

Daly and Paige were arguing as Ken excused himself. He’d seen enough bloodshed, and he had to think. Think about his new class, for one thing.

[Negotiator]. Ken had told Luan and Aiko about it immediately of course, but no one else. He hadn’t known it was a class you could get, but it made sense. And the Skills he’d gotten! [Polite Demeanor] and [Amateur Linguist].

He could understand [Polite Demeanor]—apparently it made him look and smell less like someone who lifted corpses each day. According to Luan and Aiko, it made them want to talk to him more than anyone else, if only to escape the foul odor everyone else in the company had.

But [Amateur Linguist]? That was more intriguing. Ken had tried to use it, but apparently it was a passive Skill rather than one he could use. It seemed to help with his ability to speak English, and perhaps other languages, if he knew them.

The Skill didn’t make his speech that much markedly better, but suddenly Kenjiro could understand words in English without first having to translate them into Japanese. In short, he began to think in English, which

made his ability to reply and comprehend what people were saying far easier. Aiko was purely jealous.

“So unfair! I want that Skill!”

Ken was very grateful for it, but he had no idea whether having the [Negotiator] class was a good thing, or whether it was useless. Luan was of the opinion any class was good news, but Kenjiro had heard a girl from the Netherlands saying that one class was best because of...something to do with maximum levels in a video game? Her opinion was being hotly debated among those who played video games.

He didn't know what he was looking for in camp, aside from a distraction, but Ken found it in an instant when he saw Captain Quallet arguing with a group of Centaurs, one of whom was wearing important-looking armor. Well, arguing was a bit of an understatement. Quallet was bellowing at them.

“We can't do our *jobs* if you lot won't give us access! I don't—no, I don't *care* where your patrols are! The corpses are *there*, and if you want us to get rid of them, you'll give us access!”

He was yelling at the Centaur officer, who was getting more offended by the minute. Ken hurried over, not knowing what he was doing, but knowing in his heart that Quallet was doing exactly the wrong thing if he wanted to convince the Centaurs of anything.

Unlike Dullahans and Lizardfolk, the third predominant species of Baleros, Centaurs, were neither taciturn nor talkative. They probably fit between both Lizardfolk and Dullahan temperaments when it came to how social they could be, but, and this was a big but, they had a temper. Collectively. As a species.

If there was a ranking for bad-tempered species, Centaurs would probably be at the top of that list, competing for first place with Drakes and Minotaurs, although Ken had never met representatives of those species.

Centaurs were touchy, prideful, and reminded Ken a bit of his grandmother. They didn't accept bad manners *at all*, and the slightest offense was instantly corrected, regardless if it caused trouble for all parties involved. Right now Quallet was digging himself a hole by shouting at an officer.

The angry [Mercenary Captain] had a hand on his axe and the Centaur officer looked ready to pull out his bow and shoot him. Kenjiro heard the Centaur speaking curtly to Quallet.

“Our territory is being patrolled to keep the damned Dullahans *away* from our camps. Twice now they have tried to attack us with [Rogues] and [Assassins]. My [Commander] demands to know how we know your forces can be trusted.”

Quallet growled.

“I told you, you empty-headed donkey—”

Ken saw the Centaur officer’s eyes narrow and jumped into the conversation. Literally. He nearly knocked Quallet aside. The [Captain] stumbled, eyes widening with fury. He rounded on Ken, but Ken was busy speaking to the Centaur officer. He spread his arms wide, smiling as best he could.

“Honored friends, we would humbly like to request permission to cross into your territory. We intend no disrespect, but we...must painfully intrude because of our duties. We mean no offense. And we will identify ourselves as best we can.”

The officer eyed Ken as Quallet opened a furious mouth, and then closed it as he saw what Ken was doing.

“Hmf. So you say. But how will we identify your people?”

“Banners. We have one—”

Again, Ken interrupted Quallet. This time the [Captain] let him speak.

“If it is agreeable, we will raise our company banner. It is illuminated, and the rest of our company will carry lanterns to identify ourselves. We will respond to any challenges, and, we would like to cooperate more sincerely, we will stick to an agreed-upon area of your choosing.”

It was what Quallet was going to say—what the Gravetender’s Fist company did every time, but the wording of it was key. Ken deferentially let the officer think for a moment, and then the Centaur spoke grudgingly.

“That is adequate. We will specify the location before nightfall. Do not stray.”

Ken bowed his head and thanked the Centaur as he and his soldiers trotted off. Then he turned and saw Quallet staring hard at him. Part of Ken's elated heart went up his throat. But Quallet didn't berate him. Instead, he nodded at Ken.

"Good job. You have some kind of [Diplomat] class?"

"Um. No sir. I have just received the [Negotiator] class."

"Same thing."

Quallet grunted. He paused, and looked at the Centaurs' backs. Then he spat. Ken winced, but none of the Centaurs noticed.

"In that case, you'll be dealing with both sides from now on. I hate bowing and scraping to the Centaurs, but they're touchy. As for the Dullahans—if it comes to it, just bow to the one in the most polished armor. You know that?"

Ken nodded. Quallet eyed him and then clapped him on the shoulder. Ken staggered.

"Keep it up. If you can talk us out of more trouble, I'll give you a bonus."

He walked off. Ken massaged his shoulder, wishing people weren't so intimate. But he smiled. And later that day, dozing, he leveled up again. Then he woke up. His smile faded. Ken went back to the battlefield and began hauling bodies. There was no happiness in that.

This night Gravetender's Fist was working in a wooded area, part of the Centaur's marked territory. They'd heard a stern injunction from Quallet and the other officers not to stray far from the banner, and each group had filled their lantern's oil so it shone brightly in the night.

Now Ken and the others walked past trees, some marked by combat, felled by blasts of magic or powerful Skills. They had to be especially alert for zombies hidden in the shadow of trees, but they were used to the routine enough to talk in low voices.

“They are talking about leaving?”

Aiko whispered to Luan as Ken helped both of them drag a heavy Lizardman in broken armor to the pile. Luan nodded, looking angry.

“The Americans want to go. They’re saying this job is shit—which it is—and they want to abandon the company. They’re saying we can desert and head back to one of the cities, sell our swords and armor maybe.”

“That is a bad idea. Isn’t it?”

Ken stared at Luan, heart pounding at the thought. Leave the company? If they did, they’d have to leave the neutral zone. At night or by day made no difference. If they were caught—

Luan nodded, looking angry.

“I told them—the others told them—it’s a terrible idea! But the Americans are fed up with hauling these bodies. I can’t blame them for that, but a handful of maggots here is better than dying. They think we can do it though, and they’re going to bring it up tomorrow.”

“We must talk to the others.”

Aiko’s face was pale. Luan nodded, and shifted his hold on the Dullahan.

“Shit. I can’t see. Where are the others?”

“Back there.”

Today Ken, Aiko, and Luan had paired with Quexa and three other Lizardfolk. It was Quexa who had the lantern. Ken lowered the Dullahan’s body while Luan adjusted his grip. They waited for the Lizardfolk to catch up—they were struggling to carry an obese Centaur.

“Never thought I’d see a fat Centaur. He looks round. I wonder if that’s how they got him. Too big of a target? Or was he too slow to run away? If a Centaur is too fat, does it just waddle around?”

Luan commented as he watched the Lizardfolk swearing loudly, trying to move the Centaur.

“At least it was not a zombie. That would be very hard to kill.”

Ken grinned, imagining an undead Centaur waddling towards him in the darkness. Aiko giggled, putting her hand up to her mouth and then snatching it down. Her hands, like every other part of her body, were filthy.

Luan laughed. He turned towards Ken, about to say something, and then there was a whistling sound. He blinked, and Ken heard a *thunk*.

Something sprouted from Luan's chest. He gasped, and then Aiko screamed. The Lizardfolk dropped the Centaur and Quexa shouted.

"Attack!"

Shouts rang out as shadows in the forest suddenly turned into galloping shapes. Ken reached for Luan as his friend sagged to the ground.

"Luan? Luan?"

There was an arrow in his side. Ken reached for it automatically, but someone caught his hand. A Lizardman shook his head as Quexa ran over, waving her lantern and shouting desperately at the Centaurs galloping around them.

"We're not enemies! Gravetender's Fist! We're—"

There was chaos. Ken heard pounding feet and voices, and then officer Raeh was there.

"Back off!"

He shouted at Ken and the others and fumbled at his belt.

"Healing potion. Here! Snap the arrow off and pour it in—the arrow should come out. I've got to stop us from being killed!"

He stood up and waved his hands at the Centaurs, shouting. Ken bent over Luan. The man's face was pale and beaded with sweat. Ken reached for the arrow, hesitated.

"I'll hold him. Do it."

Quexa and the Lizardman seized Luan. Ken looked at Aiko. She grabbed the arrow and he used his hands and tried to snap it.

It was hard. The arrow's shaft was thick and as he moved the arrow Luan woke up and began *screaming*. Ken heard Quexa shout and he tried to break the shaft. He felt it splinter, and then it *snapped*.

“Healing potion!”

Aiko pulled the bottle out frantically and removed the stopper. She splashed the liquid into Luan’s wound and Ken watched the skin seal over. The broken wood shaft of the arrow popped out of the wound, but the arrowhead did not. Had it passed through his body? In any event, Luan stopped thrashing.

“Luan?”

Ken held his breath. Then Luan opened his eyes. He blinked, and then spoke.

“I thought I was a goner.”

Luan grinned at them, face covered in sweat, still very pale. Ken and Aiko smiled in relief. Luan laughed shakily. He sat up to say something, and then his face went white. He cried out in agony.

“What’s wrong? Luan?”

Aiko reached for him, but Luan knocked her hand away. He pressed his hands towards his side, and to Ken’s horror, he saw the wound was opening back up. Luan fell back, screaming again as the wound tore open a second time.

Horried, Aiko reached for the potion to use it again, but Quexa stopped her. She called out.

“It’s not working! Sergeant Raeh!”

The Centaurs were gone, at least for now. Raeh came running back over, demanding to know why they hadn’t used the potion. When he heard what had happened he swore.

“It was some kind of enchanted shaft. Damn those four-legged bastards!”

He knelt by Luan’s side as the younger man cried out in pain. Raeh didn’t touch the wound, but he looked grimly at the head of the shaft.

“Whatever’s in there is still cutting him up from the inside. You—boy. Did the entire arrow come out?”

“No—no, only the—the shaft.”

“Damn it. It was an enchanted arrow after all!”

Raeh looked grimly at the wound. He beckoned for Quexa to bring the lantern over, and peered at the oozing wound. He pulled a knife out grimly, and then hesitated.

“I can’t...tell where it is. I need to cut it out before the healing potion can work, but—”

“Cut it out?”

Aiko was horrified. Raeh helplessly looked around Luan’s side as he thrashed.

“It could be anywhere in there. The enchanted arrowheads are nasty—some of them move. If I don’t get it right off, your friend will die. We can’t use healing potions until I get it—I—”

His hands were trembling. He didn’t know where to cut, and he thought he’d miss. Raeh hesitated, and Ken saw his hand tighten on the grip of the dagger. He raised it, and Ken caught his arm.

“No!”

“It has to be done! Move over boy—I’ve got only one chance to help your friend. It’s that or slit his throat, because he’ll die in agony—”

“No! There has to be a—a hospital, yes? A doctor? Someone who can perform surgery?”

There had to be. But Raeh just stared at Ken and shook his head.

“There’s no one like that.”

He raised the dagger, and Ken felt true despair in his heart as he saw Raeh’s haunted gaze. That was when Quallet found them. The [Captain] ran towards them, axe drawn, [Sergeant] Xor following.

“Raeh! What the hell’s going on here?”

Raeh explained in short sentences and both Quallet and Xor knelt by Luan. Their appraisal of the situation was the same.

“It’s got to come out, but damn me if I don’t know where. ”

“He’s losing blood. A bad cut and he’ll be dead in minutes. We can’t fish around in his guts, Captain Marshhand. It might be kinder to—”

Xor was speaking, but it all seemed far away. Ken stood in an oasis of shock and horror, watching the moment play out as if it were on a screen or far away. There was static in his ears. Aiko was gripping Luan's hand, he was screaming—Raeh had the knife.

Then Quallet looked up. He had the same empty look in his eyes, as of someone expecting to see only death. But he saw Ken, and something flickered in his gaze.

“No. Not us. There's another way.”

“What?”

Quallet stood up. He turned to his two officers.

“I'll handle matters here. Raeh, get these two an escort and a white flag. There's a spot to the north where a [Doctor] works. Have them get—Luan—over there. If they're quick and lucky, this [Doctor] might be able to save him.”

“Are you sure?”

Raeh looked skeptical, but Quallet nodded.

“It's their best shot. If we don't try, he's dead either way. You know that. There's no way we'll find an arrowhead, but if what I've heard about this 'Last Light' is true, the [Doctor] might be able to.”

A [Doctor]. The word dragged Ken back into reality. He looked at Aiko, and saw the same desperation in her eyes. It was something to cling to. Ken knelt by Luan as Raeh turned and started shouting.

“Hold on, Luan.”

It was a stretcher they used to carry Luan, the same kind they used to haul bodies or bits of bodies. It was filthy, and Luan screamed when they put him on it, but they had no choice.

They carried Luan on the stretcher, Ken, Aiko, and Quexa, while the Lizardman carried the white flag. They ran out of the woods, trying to run and not jostle Luan or trip all at the same time. They ran through the forest as the sun began to rise, searching desperately, praying.

That was how Ken met the [Doctor] known as the Last Light. He arrived in a small camp as the sun rose and Luan's blood ran from his side.

It dripped from the stretcher and fell onto the wet ground, among the grass and mud. Bugs landed to feed on the red liquid, and in the valley, two armies gathered to fight once more.

And the bodies came in, the wounded, the desperate. Ken and Aiko stood with Luan, one among many. Waiting for her, hoping she was real. The voices cried out, begged, pleaded. For salvation, relief—

For a [Doctor].

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1.04 D

Quallet Marshhand was shouting at a Centaur. He knew it was a stupid thing to do. Centaurs were belligerent, touchy, and the only way to get them to agree to something was to flatter them. But Quallet was fed up, and there were some times when he just needed to scream at something.

Like now.

The Centaur commander was clearly unhappy at being shouted at, and kept trying to snap at Quallet. His soldiers were also trying to be menacing, but Quallet knew he was in the right. He snapped at the ash-colored Centaur as his company worked in the darkness, putting the undead to rest and burning the rest of the corpses.

“No, you listen to *me*. That was my company you shot at! We announced ourselves and carried both a banner and night lanterns! How could you not see—”

“He was not standing with the lantern.”

“He was *ten feet away from it*! How could you not tell they were together? They were hauling a dead Dullahan. If that didn’t tip your idiotic soldiers off—”

“The Dullahans have disguised themselves so before.”

The Centaur was unmoved. He glared down at Quallet, looking uncomfortable at his patrol’s attack on Quallet’s soldiers, but equally enraged.

“The Dullahans have been attacking our camps disguised as your people. They, damn them, have done this twice now!”

“That does not justify what your men did! You *attacked* my soldiers—shot one with an enchanted arrow! If he dies—”

“If he dies, we will pay the blood price. But we will not change our methods. Not now.”

The officer’s face had locked up into a stubborn rictus. Quallet stared at him, shaking with fury.

“And how am I supposed to stop that from happening again?”

“Stay within our designated areas. Identify yourselves.”

“We *did* that—if you want our company to do our duty, keep your soldiers away from mine! Because I promise you, if this happens a second time I will cancel our contract and demand full pay for—”

“Enough.”

The Centaur cut Quallet off and the [Mercenary Captain] nearly drew his axe right there and then.

“We must continue patrolling. I will instruct my soldiers and tomorrow negotiations will begin over reparations and perhaps changing the location your company works. Until then, keep close to your lanterns.”

He whirled and trotted away, rather than continue arguing with Quallet. His soldiers left too, wincing as Quallet let loose a set of invectives that made the battle-hardened warriors flinch. Quallet would have liked to do more than curse.

But there was nothing he could do. Quallet stomped away to speak with Raeh and Xor. He immediately pulled back all of the company within range of the banner and made them move together at all times. Less corpses would be disposed of, but he wasn’t about to lose more soldiers than he already had.

Luan. The enchanted arrow had gone deep into his side. Quallet had seen Raeh’s eyes, seen the fear. The only way to get it out was to cut into the flesh and bone and find the arrowhead...a tiny thing somewhere in all that blood and guts. There was no way Luan would have survived if Raeh had done it. Maybe this [Doctor] could save him. But Quallet feared the young man was already dead.

“Luan? Luan! Stay awake. Please!”

Ken knelt by his friend’s side, speaking urgently to Luan as his eyes flickered. The black-skinned South African was shaking, sweat beading on

his forehead.

He was dying. Blood was seeping from his arrow wound, staining the clumsy bandage that Aiko had tied around his side. Aiko was holding Luan's hand as he groaned and shivered. That was all she could do. Ken looked around frantically.

"Is the [Doctor] here? My friend needs help!"

He was speaking—shouting at—a pale warrior with a halberd. He was a Selphid. His body was that of a Lizardman, but the scales were pale, close to white. The body was dead, but something else looked down at Ken and shook his head.

"Wait. The [Doctor] is still sleeping. She has worked without rest for over a day now. When she wakes, she will see your friend."

Ken opened his mouth, but the Selphid stared at him.

"Quiet, or I will remove you. That will not help your friend."

Ken closed his mouth. Luan was at the head of a line of wounded soldiers. There were only a few as the fighting had barely begun. It was just past dawn. But some of the soldiers were badly wounded, bandaged, unable to be healed by potions, carried by their friends to wait for the [Doctor] like Luan.

Some were already dead. Ken's stomach was a knot of fear, but he made himself grip Luan's other hand and wait.

"Give him more healing potion, Aiko."

She did. Raeh had pressed the remaining bottle into her hands as he'd sent them to look for the [Doctor]. It could not heal the wound so long as the enchanted arrow was in place, but every time she carefully poured more into the wound, Luan's color would get better and he seemed to grow in strength. But then the arrow's magic would open the wound again, and he would scream.

Life went in, life went out. But Ken saw that the healing potion was not putting as much in as went out of Luan over time. He was getting weaker. He needed help. And the [Doctor] was asleep.

It felt like hours before she woke. When she did, Ken knew in an instant because the Selphid who had been standing guard over the lines of the wounded turned his head. From a small tent a form emerged, blinking in the light of the day. She turned her head and Ken saw a Human face. For some reason that reassured him. He had wondered if the [Doctor] was a Dullahan, but she looked...normal.

Then she began to lurch down the hill and Ken wondered if he'd made a mistake. She couldn't be who Luan was waiting for.

When Kenjiro first saw the woman known as the Last Light, the famed [Doctor] of the battlefield up close, he thought he was looking at another zombie. Her skin was olive in color, but pale. Her hands were covered in blood, as was her clothing. Her brown hair was covered by an odd cap—a cut-down leather helmet stained with sweat.

She looked as if she needed a [Doctor] herself. One of her arms was practically white, as if blood flow had been constricted there. Her steps were brisk, but she stumbled twice as she approached the line of wounded. There was red in her eyes. Broken blood vessels.

When she spoke, her voice was hoarse.

“What happened to him?”

Ken looked at his friends. Quexa and a Lizardman had come with them, helping carry Luan. They were sitting by Luan, and looked at Ken. So did Aiko. So Ken took a breath and tried to explain.

“He—he was shot by an arrow. A magical—he does not heal. It is here.”

He showed the woman the wound and the [Doctor] knelt. She appraised his side for a second and then stood. She nearly fell down again, and the Selphid guard caught her.

“Arrow wound. Understood. Don't move him. Stay with your friend. If he wakes, don't let him get up. Keep him still, got it?”

“Yes, but—”

Ken broke off. The woman was already moving past him, speaking to the soldiers second in line. She knelt by a man with a broken sword blade protruding from his stomach, nodded. Ken stared at the piece of metal—it

was frosted over. Magical? The man with it in his stomach was shaking uncontrollably and moaning. But the [Doctor] did not see to him either. She moved on to the next wounded soldier, then the next.

“Wait!”

The [Doctor] had nearly reached the end of the line when Ken ran towards her. The Selphid barred the way. Ken stopped and pointed at Luan.

“Will you help him?”

“Yes. Later. I have other patients to attend to first.”

Ken turned and saw two other Selphids with pale bodies carefully picking up the Soldier with the enchanted blade in his stomach. He gaped.

“But we are—first!”

The woman shook her head.

“Not the point. I am triaging. I must decide who needs attention first. This is not a situation where the first who arrive get treated first. I will save those who need my help most, and then move on to the less critically injured.”

She’d raised her voice so everyone waiting could hear. Ken understood her words, but couldn’t accept them.

“But my friend—”

“He has more time. I will see to him when I can.”

The [Doctor] turned away. Ken took a step, but the Selphid barred his path, his face grim. Ken stared helplessly at the Lizardman’s face and the intelligence lurking behind the dead features. He saw the [Doctor] move on, and then hesitate. She turned and spoke crisply.

“I am a [Doctor]. That means I save lives, no matter who it is I treat. I will try to save your friend—if I can. But I can’t promise anything. I will get to him as fast as I can. But you must wait.”

And that was it. Ken went back to Luan. In less than a minute, the woman had finished her surveying of the patients. She marked them—Ken could see how she pointed and the Selphid guard laid colored stones by the wounded. Green for the least wounded. Yellow for moderate wounds and

red for those about to die. Black meant they were dead or...or they weren't going to be treated.

Luan was yellow. He was going to die, but not as soon as some. The [Doctor] strode up to a tent where the other Selphids had carried the first patient. Someone came out with a bowl of healing potion he dribbled on those with the red stones. It helped.

Ken applied healing potion to Luan's wound. The skin closed. Broke open. Luan screamed. He waited, staring at the tent. It felt like hours passed before the tent flaps opened and the man with the enchanted blade in his stomach was carried out—minus the blade.

That was the first. There were five more to go. Ken watched another body go in as a group of ragged Human soldiers stared at the tent. Hours passed—Quexa told him it was minutes. The tent flaps opened, and a corpse came out.

Ken felt his stomach drop. Another body went in as the Selphid guard laid the body down and the soldiers, the friends of the female Lizardwoman who'd taken five arrows to the chest, wept and clung to each other in grief. The tent flaps were already closing around the third wounded soldier marked with a red stone.

A corpse came out. Another body came in. Another corpse. The fifth soldier lived, but his arm was gone. As the sixth came in, Luan started gasping and his eyes started rolling back into his head.

“Luan!”

Aiko was clinging to him, whispering to him in English and Japanese. But it was no good. The wound kept bleeding and the healing potion had run out. Ken stared helplessly at the stained bandages, crimson from all the blood loss and remembered some of the medical techniques he'd seen on TV. He had never been trained, but he couldn't just sit back any longer!

“We should—出血を止めまれ! Apply compress—”

He reached for Luan's side, guided by only a few memories of what to do with an open wound. Apply pressure? Where? Along the edges?

Aiko was white-faced, hands hovering over the open wound. Ken heard a shout as he reached for Luan.

“Don’t touch him!”

The Selphid guard stopped Ken as Quexa and the Lizardman stood up, just as worried. The Selphid pulled Ken back, explaining as Ken protested weakly.

“It’s an Evercut Arrow. It cannot be removed without opening him up, you see? If you shake your friend about, it will cut through his insides. Do not move him any more, and do not let him move.”

“But he is *dying*.”

“Yes.”

The Selphid looked him in the eyes, calmly. He had seen death. He lived in a corpse. He pulled Ken back as Quexa took Aiko and hugged her.

The Selphid’s name was Calectus. He made Ken sit, drink some water from Ken’s water flask. Ken had forgotten he had it. Calectus didn’t give Ken any false assurances, or hopes. He just told Ken to leave Luan, to not make things worse.

“Hope that he lives long enough for Doctor Geneva to see him.”

So Ken did. He prayed under his breath by Luan’s side as the sixth patient left the tent a corpse. Then it was Luan’s turn.

Geneva didn’t calculate her success rate as she worked. If she did, she would have given up long ago in despair. But she couldn’t ignore the brutal arithmetic of life and death.

Some lived, some died. Sometimes Geneva would save four, twelve people in a row. Then she’d be wondering when the next patient would come in that she couldn’t save. Or sometimes she’d fail to save five people in a row, and keep praying the next patient was treatable. Because they had to be. The next one had to be. It was a game her mind played. It tried to find logic and patterns in chaos.

As the Selphid assistants took the sixth body outside, Geneva rested her hand against the table. She knew who was coming next. The black-skinned youth with the enchanted arrow in his side. She didn't know if she could save him.

"Be ready Okasha. I need you to move fast. He will have lost a lot of blood and I need to find the arrow before I can heal him with a potion."

"Understood."

Okasha moved Geneva's right arm up, blotting at her sweaty forehead with a damp cloth. Geneva saw the flaps open, and then the young man was on the table in front of her.

"Beginning the incision."

Geneva didn't need to do any diagnosing. She knew what had hit the young man. The Roving Arrow company had begun using the Evercut arrows a few days ago and Geneva had seen too many cases of these wounds to count. The arrows lodged in the inside and kept moving, slowly digging through organs and preventing healing until the patient died.

Swiftly, she cut with her scalpel across the young man's chest, cutting open cloth, and then she cut again, opening up his side. She didn't worry about infection or disease—her leveling up had granted her the invaluable Skill of [Sterile Field], an upgrade over [Sterile Equipment]. Nothing in a radius around her would be affected by unsanitary conditions, although they would if they left her presence.

So Geneva's scalpel was clean as it sliced into the young man's side. He opened his mouth and cried out—he was awake. The two Selphids immediately leapt forwards and held him down as Geneva tuned out the sounds he was making. She adjusted for his struggling and cut.

"I can see the entry wound. Going deeper."

His flesh parted under the fine blade. Geneva stared into pulsating insides and saw red. The arrow had cut into the young man's insides. The blood was concealing everything. Geneva's eyes darted around, looking for the telltale glint of metal. Nothing.

If she were in a hospital she'd have a suction machine to clear away the blood. Here she only had—

“Towel.”

Okasha moved Geneva’s right hand at her command, sponging away blood. She put the towel aside, picked up another one. It was horrible, unsanitary, and Geneva’s only option.

“Water.”

She had some water that she used to rinse away the last of the blood. Now Geneva could see. And she saw...

Nothing. She could tell where the arrow had ripped through the young man’s side, into his liver. But it wasn’t in his liver anymore. He had stopped struggling, either passed out from the pain or...no, he was still alive. But she had to move quickly.

“Where did it go? Do you see it?”

“There.”

A voice in Geneva’s ear, too quiet for anyone to hear but her. Geneva felt her hand move. She could see the passage of the arrowhead now, though. From the liver, something had cut...Geneva saw an opening in the stomach lining and went for it. And at last she saw it, a tiny piece of orange metal, glinting and—moving—among the red flesh.

“Forceps.”

They were in her hand. Geneva knew what to do now, and carefully maneuvered them towards the arrowhead as it squirmed, cutting into the stomach. She took a breath, and then gripped it tightly. Instantly, she felt tension in the forceps as she tried to lever the arrowhead out of the flesh.

“It’s fighting me. Careful—”

Geneva twisted, and then *flicked* the arrowhead out of the wound. It flew off of the surgical table and onto the ground, still buried in a bit of flesh. One of the Selphid aides ran over to capture the arrowhead, taking care not to let it touch his skin.

“There. Check for fragments—where’s the healing potion?”

Okasha had it ready. Geneva swept through the rest of the body, but found nothing else wrong. She was running out of time.

“Apply the potion now.”

She normally used it sparingly, but the arrowhead had cut through so many parts of the body...Geneva closed the stomach, liver, and other damaged organs and then sutured the incision she'd made before closing that too. It helped, she found, and reduced the need for as much healing potion.

And then it was done. The young man went out and Geneva heard a scream of relief and shouts. That lifted a tiny part of her spirits. But then the next body came in, this time a soldier who had some kind of spell that was eating away at his legs, both of them. She had no way to stop it. She had to amputate. And then...

And then it was evening. The bodies stopped coming in. Either the soldiers were being killed off without a chance to be rescued, or all the injuries were healable with potions. That happened. Geneva stumbled out of her tent and found herself blinking up at a sun setting in the sky.

“Miss [Doctor]?”

A voice interrupted her. She turned and saw a man in armor with a helmet tucked under his arm and an axe at his belt. Calectus, the Selphid guard and highest-level warrior who'd volunteered to protect her, was watching him warily. Geneva took a step and nearly fell. The man caught her arm.

“Thank you. Ah, can I help you?”

“You already have, Miss. My name is Quallet Marshhand. I am the commander of Gravetender's Fist, a suppression company hired for this engagement.”

“Oh. The ones who dispose of corpses.”

Quallet nodded as he and Geneva sat on some chairs that someone had found. He studied her, and she studied him. He was much what she had expected from a company commander. She'd seen and treated many by now. She was clearly not what he'd been expecting, though.

“This morning you saved one of my soldiers. I am grateful, although I don't know what the custom is. My company can offer you—”

Oh. That was why he was here. Geneva sighed as she felt exhaustion catching up with her. She cut Quallet off brusquely.

“I’m a [Doctor]. I don’t charge fees for my work. If you want to donate, that’s fine, but I tend to each patient that comes to me without bias. I don’t take sides in war. Saving lives is my only priority.”

He blinked and considered this, not offended by her abrupt interruption.

“I see. In that case, let me offer you some money and my thanks. The young man you saved—he’s a good soldier.”

“They all are.”

Geneva tried to smile at him, and failed. She stood and shook Quallet’s hand. He gave some coins to Calectus—she saw silver and coppers, no gold. Geneva didn’t know whether to be insulted or not. She didn’t really care. Some commanders gave her nothing if she saved hundreds of their men, others, like Quallet, felt the need to come and thank her for each one.

She wasn’t doing this to be paid. She was...she was...she just had to do it. Because she’d sworn an oath? Because it was right? No. Because it was all she could do. It was all she could rationalize herself doing in this terrible world filled with blood and death.

Troubled by that thought, she turned away and nearly fell. Her leg shot out as Geneva nearly collapsed forward. Okasha steadied Geneva and spoke.

“Rest.”

“I’m fine. I should stay up. If there’s more—”

“You didn’t get enough sleep last night. If there are more wounded, I will wake you. But your mind is exhausted. You sleep. I will eat and rest us both.”

“I—I should—”

Geneva shook her head as she felt at her pocket. But Okasha was insistent, and Geneva knew what she was about to do.

“Sleep, Geneva. You must sleep. You have worked enough.”

Darkness engulfed Geneva's mind in a moment. She felt oblivion come. It was welcome.

Okasha had never invaded a living person's body up until the moment a few months ago when she had had no choice. It was anathema to her kind, and punishable by death. But a body was a body, and she had adapted quickly and learned that a living body was far different from a dead one.

For one thing, a living body reacted to secretions Okasha could produce, as well as the ones it naturally secreted. Okasha had learned that long ago and made use of that fact to get Geneva to rest when the woman needed it.

She just had to trigger Geneva's brain to secrete a little bit of the chemicals that induced drowsiness, the thing that Geneva called 'melatonin'.

Oh, the things Humans came up with. How could they come up with a name for something Selphids had poked and prodded at for millennia? And yet, Geneva had told Okasha things about how the Human body worked that even the Selphids hadn't known.

"Or perhaps we did know, once. Before our kind was hunted for the crime of stealing bodies from the living."

It was Geneva's voice, but Okasha who whispered with it. To differentiate between the two, Okasha lowered the range of Geneva's vocal chords to make her voice deeper. She steered Geneva back towards camp, heading towards the [Doctor]'s tent.

Geneva's mind was asleep; Okasha was in control. The Selphid only took full authority over her body when Geneva was asleep or in dire need. And she was uncomfortable with that, to be honest. What she was doing was abhorrent to Selphid culture. It had been banned by ancient treaties under threat of total extinction for their race. If Okasha was revealed to be possessing a live body, she would be destroyed, she had no doubt.

And yet, Geneva would be paralyzed without her. For all the [Doctor]'s genius, she had no knowledge of a way to cure damage to the spinal cord,

and she had been struck by Thriss' mace on the back of her neck. She would die, unable to move anything but her head without Okasha. And she couldn't die. She was too valuable to the world.

Okasha saw that. That was why she helped Geneva, looked after her. That was also why six Selphids had joined Geneva's camp. It was one of them who walked towards Okasha now. Calectus, most senior and highest level of the Selphids. He had come at Okasha's behest, and he knew more than he let on.

For instance, about the fact that Okasha was in Geneva's body. He knew Okasha had taken over Geneva as well—Selphids could see through body postures better than anyone else and so his face was disapproving as he looked at Okasha. He still had not forgiven her transgression, and spoke to her brusquely, as a senior to a junior.

After all, Okasha was only a Level 23 [Rogue] and now, a Level 15 [Medical Assistant]. Whereas Calectus was...

A Level 36 [Honor Guard]. Okasha stood in awe of him and humbly bobbed her head as Calectus motioned her to the tent where food was served to the wounded and Geneva, when she remembered to eat.

"She is asleep?"

He asked this as brusque confirmation as Okasha ate with Geneva's body. The Selphid paused to savor the hot food—it was tastier than when she inhabited a dead person's body. Geneva's taste buds were all intact, and the sensation was blissful.

"Yes. She didn't level today."

"You can tell when it happens?"

Calectus frowned at Okasha as the Selphid nodded.

"If I listen, I think I can almost hear the announcement myself. But it's always inaudible...I wonder if our predecessors worked with their hosts, rather than just controlled them?"

"Idle speculation. It was a mistake and it cost our kind everything."

The older Selphid was disapproving. Okasha nodded meekly. He studied her, frowning as she finished her plate and filled it with a second

helping. Geneva needed the energy.

“Do not take risks, Okasha. I do not like you forcing your host to sleep; even that is risky because we do not have the experience of interacting with a living host. Take no chances while you are working with her. Let her take no chances. The value of Geneva Scala’s life far outweighs yours or mine. So we have agreed.”

Geneva nodded. Calectus paused. She looked up at him. The Lizardman’s body he had recently inhabited was all very well, but she knew he was more at home with Dullahans. She coughed as a bit of food went down her lungs and fished it out with her Selphid body.

“How long will you stay with Geneva, Calectus?”

He shrugged.

“As long as it takes. If there is any Human, any person in this world that can save our people from the Wasting, it is her. Allow her to reach Level 30, and then, perhaps suggest to her that it is time to leave. I do not like the way this battle is going. Both sides are growing far more...savage.”

Okasha nodded. She’d felt it too. She and Calectus were soldiers, and the use of Evercut arrows spoke to a desire to hurt the enemy badly. Such arrows could only be used once and they were *expensive*...the Centaurs wanted to beat the Dullahans at all costs.

The two Selphids made no more conversation. Okasha finished eating and returned Geneva to her tent. There she made Geneva lie down. Time to sleep. Okasha let herself drift, relinquishing control of her body. Selphids slept like Humans.

A few hours later, Geneva awoke. She sat up slowly, and whispered.

“Okasha?”

There was no response. It was dark out, and the Selphid was asleep. Geneva was about to get up to pee—that was what had woken her up, but she felt at her pocket first.

Tucked away in her pants was a small stone. Geneva carefully pulled it out, trying to sense if Okasha was waking up. She was not.

Slowly, Geneva brought the stone up and tapped the surface. Instantly, she heard rustling sounds, and then a voice.

“Or perhaps we did know, once. Before our kind was hunted for the crime of stealing bodies from the living.”

It was in Geneva’s voice, but she had never said the words. Geneva shivered as she listened on. The she held the small stone carefully between her fingers as it replayed the events of the last hour after she’d activated it.

It was a small voice recorder, a magically carved rune embedded in the center of an azurite stone. Geneva had bought it a while back and Okasha had forgotten she carried it. It took just a touch to activate. Geneva could do it when putting her hands in her pockets and the Selphid wouldn’t pay attention if she wasn’t in full control of Geneva’s body.

“Hm.”

The conversation between Okasha and Calectus played as Geneva lay back in bed. She listened; closing her eyes for a moment, and then shook her head.

They should have asked her. But help was help. She stood up, and went to pee. In the morning there would be more wounded to tend to, and Geneva was still tired. This was her routine. This was how every day went.

This was her life, now.

“Luan-san, you’re awake!”

Ken and Aiko were there when Luan opened his eyes, as evening had begun. He sat up, gasped, felt at his side, and looked around.

“What happened?”

“The [Doctor] healed you. Can you tell? Do you remember?”

Aiko hugged Luan fiercely as he blinked, confused, and then put his hand to his head. He shook his head as Ken tried to give him an explanation of all that had passed.

“Shame. I thought I was a goner.”

He stood up, shakily, and then felt at his side again.

“I’m cured! I can’t believe it. What was the [Doctor] like?”

“Very strange. She was...she was very much like a doctor from our world.”

Ken told Luan about what had happened as Aiko went to get him some food and let the others know Luan was awake. Luan frowned.

“Like how?”

“She was talking about ‘triage’ and needing a ‘blood transfusion’ and many other complicated terms. I did not know there *were* [Doctors] in this world.”

Luan frowned.

“That is odd. How would someone know about blood transfusions here? Unless...does everyone know about that? That is a very advanced medical concept, I think.”

Ken nodded. Then he hesitated. Aiko rushed back in with some hot gruel and Luan devoured it. Ken took Aiko aside and whispered to her.

“Blood transfusion. That is—what is a ‘transfusion’, Aiko?”

“輸血.”

“Oh! That is odd! Luan, do you think she might be—”

Luan stared at Ken, and both felt a sudden jolt of excitement. It couldn’t be. Could it? Ken tried to remember—it was a young woman, a *Human* young woman who’d talked to him. A [Doctor]. That was a word from his world. Here [Healers] were far more common. Could it be? Was there someone else?

“Maybe.”

Luan put a hand to his side again, still not quite believing he was cured. He and Ken speculated about whether a person from this world would even know what a transfusion was before Aiko told them there was trouble outside.

It was the Humans. Or rather, Ken, Aiko and Luan's group. They were arguing around the fire. They had been arguing for hours, apparently, but Ken had been too preoccupied with Luan to notice.

Now he saw Johanas shouting at Daly, pointing back at the battlefield where the Dullahans and Centaurs were still fighting.

"Those things *killed* Jessica! And those fucking Centaurs nearly killed Luan! I'm not sticking around to get killed. Let's get out of here and—"

"Fuck that!"

Daly was standing across from Johanas with a group of Australians. There was a clear divide in the group and it turned out they were arguing about leaving. Ken stared as Luan groaned and Aiko helped him into a seat. Only the groan turned out to be about the issue, which Johanas had brought up and Daly and the others didn't want to hear.

"We're *not* leaving, you bloody idiots. You heard what the Captain told us about deserters—"

"Better than dying here or hauling more fucking corpses!"

The Americans were clearly ready to split. They'd been rattled by Luan getting shot last night, and that, on top of having to deal with dead bodies every night had been the last straw. The Australians were of a different opinion, as were the other young men and women in the group.

"You wanna go? Fine. But we're not on board with this. Just because you lot are fed up, doesn't mean we all want to risk our necks."

Daly was arguing with Johanas. The American young man clearly wanted everyone to go with him. He turned to the group.

"In that case, let's vote! Democracy! Everyone who's in, raise their hands—"

Hands shot up, but Paige shouted as she crossed her arms.

"Screw your democracy! Over a third of the group is you lot. We voted last time, and that's how we ended up *here*."

There was a general agreement. Johanas flushed and opened his mouth angrily to retort. Ken turned to Luan. He caught sight of Xor and Raeh watching the disturbance at a distance, but neither officer seemed inclined

to stop the fighting so long as there wasn't violence. Quallet was ducking back into his tent—Ken spoke to Luan.

“What do you think, Luan?”

“What do I think?”

Luan's face was still pale, but he bared his teeth.

“I think the Americans have a point.”

Ken and Aiko looked at Luan, shocked. He shook his head.

“Friends, I don't know about you two, but I am *not* looking forward to going out there again. I just got shot. But—”

He frowned as the debate ended without a definitive conclusion. Daly took a swing at Johanas and both sides pulled the two apart before they could start brawling. Luan watched everyone disperse and shook his head.

“—But I don't think abandoning the company is any better. Let's talk to Daly and see what he thinks.”

It turned out that Daly and the other Australians were dead set against leaving and refusing to consider the matter.

“It's not a vote, alright? We're going to stay no matter what the others do.”

Daly spoke curtly to Luan as Aiko supported him. Ken's attention was drawn to a short, furry creature that Daly was bending down and petting. It had green fur and a white belly and huge, round ears, a long cord-like tail and small paws. It was cute. Ken had no idea where it had come from.

“What is that, Daly?”

“Cute, ain't it?”

The Australian young man grinned, forgetting his earlier ire as he bent to feed the thing a bit of bread. It squeaked—a surprisingly deep sound—and nibbled at it as two more hopped out of the brush.

“They just popped up while I was snacking. Friendly as you like. Go on, pet them.”

Ken did. To his delight, the rodent rubbed its head against his hand. Aiko immediately bent to pet it, while Luan took a seat on the ground.

“It’s like a quokka, I think. Doesn’t it look like that, Daly?”

Paige, another Australian girl with a scarred-over bite wound on one arm, reached out and stroked the little furry creature’s head. Soon, she and every Human in the company were trying to touch the affectionate creatures. Ken felt himself smiling—until one of the Lizardfolk noticed what was going on. Ken heard a shout and saw Quexa running over excitedly.

“Ooh! Look! Beriats! Don’t let it get away!”

She ran over to the large rodent that Ken had been holding in his lap. It froze at the sight of the Lizardgirl and then leapt from Ken’s lap and tried to run into the forest. Too slow. Quexa caught up with it and lifted her foot with a triumphant yell.

She *stomped* on the green-furred rodent’s back, breaking its back with a sickening *crack*. Paige cried out in horror, but in a moment the other Lizardfolk were running over. The Beriats darted away, but the Lizardfolk grabbed them and beat them against the ground, using the Beriats’ tails as a handle.

There was a moment of shock as the Humans stopped shouting and the Lizardfolk happily lifted the corpses of the Beriats up. They blinked at the stunned Humans.

“What?”

Quexa frowned.

Aiko burst into tears. Luan went to hug her as Ken edged between her and the Lizardgirl. The Lizardfolk were getting insults from all sides and were clearly not understanding the issue.

“*What?* We’ll share. Beriats taste *good* when cooked. Or raw!”

It took some doing for Ken to smooth ruffled scales—and explain to Quexa why the Humans were upset that a bunch of cute animals had been butchered before their eyes. Quexa and the other Lizardfolk didn’t really understand—they were used to killing livestock themselves, and they regarded Beriats as a pest that ate grain and stole food, for all they weren’t a physical threat.

They were a pest. But they were cute. Ken felt that should have saved the Beriats as he watched the Lizardfolk happily skin them and roast them over a fire. They had brightened up everyone's day, and now they were dead, made into hot food the Lizardfolk did indeed share around.

It was fitting of Baleros, of this place with as many horrors as marvels. Ken just wished the Beriats didn't taste so *good*. He tactfully did not eat his portion anywhere around Aiko, but he was too hungry for hot meat to turn it down when Quexa offered. Not to mention that it would have offended the Lizardgirl to have refused.

That night, Quallet mustered Gravetender's Fist and gave them a short speech before sending them out. They would no longer be working near the Centaur's camp he promised, but they were still expected to do their jobs. He didn't address Luan especially, but everyone knew Luan had been saved by a [Doctor]. Luan's group was also assigned to an area close to where Quallet planted the company banner, with less corpses and danger overall.

It still didn't make picking up bits of dead bodies easier, but at least Ken could detach his conscious mind to do it. He only paid attention to make sure Luan was fine, but the healing potion had restored the young man's strength, and Luan was in better physical shape than Ken. He was still jumpy and kept watching the shadows, but he was alright.

However, trouble started as dawn began to break. Luan pulled Ken aside as Aiko stabbed a few bodies, looking for undead.

"Hey Ken, have you seen any of the Americans?"

"No."

Ken immediately felt worried, remembering the argument of a few hours ago. Luan hadn't seen them either, and it turned out no one had.

"I don't know where they are. Neither does Daly or anyone else. They're not where they were supposed to be assigned. Xor's kicking up a fuss looking for them. Let's get back to camp. I'll tell you if something happens."

Worried, Ken finished his duties. Quallet heard about the missing Americans and would have gone looking, but it was too close to dawn. Furious, the commander ordered the company back and they reached their camp. Ken tried to stay awake as he heard Quallet interrogating Daly and the others about where Johanas and the others had gone, but he was exhausted. He hadn't slept since Luan had been shot, so he laid his head down...

"Ken. Ken! Wake up!"

It felt like a moment had passed. Ken groaned as he felt someone shake him. He protested, but the hand came again, shaking him roughly.

"Get up!"

"Just a moment Luan..."

A hand dragged Ken out of his bedroll. Ken heard Luan's voice as he woke up a bit more, and only now registered the tension in it.

"Ken, wake *up*. It's the Americans."

There was something in Luan's tone that took the exhaustion right out of Ken's mind. He got up at once, blinking around.

It was just past dawn. He hadn't slept an hour. But the instant Ken saw Luan's face, any thoughts of sleep fled.

"What is it?"

"Follow me."

Luan stepped out of the tent without explaining. Ken followed. There was something hollow in his stomach, a terrible foreboding. He was not filled with dread so much as a...certainty. He didn't want to be right.

Ken stopped when he reached the edge of the neutral zone, a place where he could look down into the valley. He expected to see the soldiers fighting, but neither side had begun. Instead, in front of the Dullahan army there were a group of eight kneeling figures. Ken's heart stopped when he recognized them.

Johanas knelt beside five girls and two guys, all American. They were lined up in front of a Dullahan. A Dullahan with an axe.

Ken didn't need any more context. He stared, white-faced at Luan. Aiko was there, trembling. So were the other Humans and the rest of Gravetender's Fist.

"They got caught sneaking through the forest last night. They're—they're going to be executed."

Executed. Ken stared down at the kneeling group of Humans as the Dullahan with the axe shouted something and the soldiers behind him roared. He felt a ringing in his ears.

"We have to stop them."

"How?"

Luan looked at him. Ken had no answer. The Dullahan stepped forwards and Aiko made a sound. Ken didn't realize he was next to her until he was putting his hands over her eyes.

"見ないで,愛子."

She didn't protest. Ken stared down at the bodies, feeling sick, horrified. The axe came up—someone stepped in front of him. Ken saw black skin. He stared at Luan's back.

"Luan—"

"You don't need to see it."

Luan's voice was low. He blocked Ken's view. Ken opened his mouth, and then heard the scream. It came from Paige. She stumbled back and he heard Daly shout and turn away.

Ken heard another shout, and more screams. He saw Luan's back trembling. There was another roar from the Dullahans, more screams, and then Luan stumbled away. Ken heard him throwing up with several other people, not all of them Human.

It was over. Ken stared down at the valley as the Dullahans raised their weapons and shouted at the Centaurs, who shook the ground with their hooves and roared back. He saw bodies without heads, a red axe being wiped clean by one of the Dullahans and horror in the eyes of the other Humans.

The battle began minutes later. But Ken stood there, just staring at the place the bodies had been. Johanas' corpse was soon lost among the fighting. But Ken remembered it. He wondered if he'd be assigned to dispose of it that night.

In that moment, Ken knew he could never go back. He looked at Luan. The young man was wiping his mouth. Vomit had stained part of his shirt. He looked at Ken, and Aiko grabbed the arms of both. Tears were streaming down her face.

"I can't do it."

That was all Luan said. Ken nodded.

"We must go."

"We do, and we will die."

Aiko's face was drained of color. Luan looked at her, and then at Ken.

"The [Doctor] knew about blood transfusions. Maybe she's from our world."

It was a slim hope, a slim chance. But Ken grasped at it.

"We can ask her."

"How?"

Aiko stared at the fighting. If they went out without a banner, they would be a target for both sides. But they'd navigated the fighting once. If they kept clear of it, and most importantly had a banner—

"A white flag. That was what Captain Quallet told us to use."

Ken stared around, hoping to see it. Luan paused.

"They keep the flag with the company banner. It's in Quallet's tent, and there's always a guard. But you can probably talk him into giving it to us."

"But it's dangerous—"

Ken hesitated. Luan looked at the battlefield and came to a swift decision.

"I can't be part of this. We can't. Let's go."

“Another world?”

Geneva had been sharpening her scalpels with a whetstone when the group of two young men and a young girl had rushed into their camp, waving a white flag. She hadn't recognized them at first, until she'd looked at the tallest young man's side. She hadn't paid attention to his face, but then she remembered the shorter young man who looked almost Japanese.

And then he'd spoken, and the world turned upside down.

The scalpel fell from her fingers. Instantly, Geneva bent and recovered it from the dirt. She stared at Kenjiro, Aiko, and Luan as if they were ghosts.

“You. You're all from—”

“You know about blood transfusions. You saved my life. You operate on people, and we've heard that you appeared a few months ago. We appeared last week. I'm from South Africa. This is Ken and Aiko. They're from Japan. Are you...like us?”

The black young man—Luan—looked at Geneva. She felt Okasha moving inside her, whispering.

“Another world? Geneva, what—”

“I am.”

The word passed from Geneva's lips. She saw the Japanese girl put a hand to her mouth, and the young Japanese man sag. With relief?

“I don't believe it.”

Luan stared at her. He walked towards her hesitantly, and reached a hand out. Geneva stared at it. And then she rose and took it.

“I'm Luan Khumalo, from South Africa. I am—I used to be a paddler. In training for the Olympics. Who are you?”

Geneva felt the grip, strong and sure. A pulse beat through Luan's fingers, and she stared into dark brown eyes, a strong, smiling face with

short hair. She hadn't looked at his face before. Her voice was hoarse as she replied.

"I—I'm Geneva Scala. I was...a medical student. I'm from America."

She saw Luan's smile vanish as she said where she was from. Suddenly, Ken had lowered his head and Aiko was crying. Geneva looked at them.

"What?"

"I didn't know. I had no idea there was...anyone from my world. I never had a chance to ask around or—I didn't know."

Geneva sat with the others, in a rare break from the fighting. No—it wasn't a break. It was that the fighting had been too fierce for anyone to bring the wounded to her, so Geneva actually had time to talk. The irony of that was bitter on her tongue as she sat with Aiko, Luan, and Ken.

And spoke. It was the first time Geneva had really talked with—with anyone. She heard the three out, listening mainly to Luan as he explained the incredible circumstances that had led them onto the same battlefield as her. Incredible, but not unbelievable. She had had the same experience. In Baleros, it was hard to find paying work for those who were unskilled—except in war.

It was the deaths of the other Americans, the other people from her country that shook Geneva the most. She hadn't heard about the executions. There had been a group of people from her world, from where she lived, perhaps from the same state, and they had lived and died so close by without her ever knowing.

"I can't stand this place. I've seen and heard of horrible shit in the countries where I come from—there are African warlords who'd fit right into this place. But I can't just do my job disposing of dead bodies while it goes on."

Luan gestured with a shaking hand at the cover of the forest, beyond which he could hear and see the fighting going on. He looked at Geneva.

“How do you stand it? You’ve been through, what, *three* battlefields?”

“Four. Counting this one.”

Geneva stared down at her hands. She’d seen so much blood and death over the past month—more bodies and horror than she’d seen in the worst videos of ER rooms at hospitals. Somehow she’d kept her sanity and mind through it all. She’d grown numb to it, at least in part.

“What is it you’re doing, Geneva-san? Why are you here?”

That came from Ken, the young Japanese man. He leaned over the table, looking curiously at her.

“Were you hired? Are you being paid to save people?”

“No. Not at all. I’m not here to...I do my job. I try to save people. That’s all.”

Geneva tried to explain. The others tried to understand. Geneva stood up and paced around, grateful that Okasha was just listening to all this. She didn’t know if she should tell them about her.

“I—I was trained to be a doctor, a medical practitioner. I wanted to be a surgeon. And this...I never graduated from medical school, but I still believe in the Hippocratic Oath. I see people dying. Soldiers. And I can help them. There *are* no medical techniques in this world. No one knows about suturing, or surgery—they don’t know about blood transfusion. Or blood types.”

Something took a hold of her tongue. Geneva found herself correcting her statement.

“Well, Selphids do. But they don’t share that knowledge.”

The others looked at her and Geneva tried to pretend nothing different had happened. She continued.

“So I do what I can. I patch people up—I can deal with injuries that healing potions can’t fix, like the arrow that hit you, Luan. But I can’t stop the fighting. I’ve just done what I can. That’s all I *can* do. I’d like to help you three, and the others, but...I can’t do anything.”

The three exchanged hopeless looks. Geneva stared at them. She knew what suppression companies did. She’d seen the undead rising—had one

appear on the operating table before Okasha bashed its brains in. That hadn't violated her oath, but it had disturbed her. There were magical, fantastical things like the undead and mages in this world, but people still bled and killed each other like they did in hers.

And now there were people in need, people from her world, frightened, without any way to protect themselves, stuck in a war and dying. Geneva felt the same urge as she did when she saw someone who was wounded. She had to help.

But how? She paced back and forth and came to a quick decision.

"If you can leave your company—I'll make sure you're fed and have a place to sleep here. I can't, won't leave. Not until this is over. But you'll be safer here than you will out there."

Luan looked at her. He was Geneva's age, maybe older. He stood.

"It's not just us. There are more—there were more, but there are still at least forty people. Can you feed us all?"

Geneva had food. The Selphids had food, rather. They'd brought it with them and provided a lot of the supplies she needed. She hesitated, and then nodded. She wasn't sure, but she had only one answer in her heart.

"Only people from our world, though. I can't ask the people with me to guard more than that. Luan, Ken, Aiko...I don't know if you'll be safer here than in your company, to tell you the truth. I don't *have* a company, and I don't dare leave this area."

They nodded. Luan stood and looked towards the sky.

"We've got to go back."

"Will you be safe going back? I could ask Calectus to—"

"We will be fine. I am a [Negotiator] and we have a flag. A white one."

Ken reassured Geneva, although she wanted to be the one to do that to him. He was pale, as were Aiko and Luan. They'd just seen their friends killed and now Geneva was handing them a hard choice. They looked at her. Aiko bowed and so did Ken. Luan nodded.

Then they were gone, leaving Geneva alone. Only, she was never alone. Okasha had heard the entire thing.

At that moment, Geneva couldn't have cared less.

"What are we going to do?"

"I don't know."

"I do."

Ken looked at Luan as they found their way back to camp. Luan's face was set. He looked at Ken and Aiko.

"I'm going to go with Geneva. I can't do this, guys. I can't—can't go out there and keep wondering if I'll die the next time a patrol thinks I'm an enemy. I nearly died once. I won't risk my life to clean up after a war. I don't know if you'll come with me, but I'm sorry. I've made up my mind."

The two Japanese college students blinked up at Luan. Ken and Aiko shared a look. Aiko was the first to speak.

"I...don't want to ever stab a dead body again!"

"Me neither."

Ken felt his entire body resonating with Luan's statement. He took a breath.

"I will go. And I hope—I hope the others will come too."

"No."

Daly raised his head and shook it. Ken saw the motion, recognized it, and still didn't comprehend.

"No? Why not?"

"I'm not going, Ken. Even if this [Doctor]'s from our world—I'm going to stay in the company."

He was sitting by the fire, somber, and he'd been alone until Ken and Luan had come to talk with him. None of the others were in the mood to speak, but Daly's decision stunned Ken. Luan sat next to Daly, eyes on his face.

"Are you worried about being safe?"

"Not that. I just don't think leaving the company's a good idea."

"Daly, what we saw this morning—"

The young man from Australia swore and turned to Luan, eyes overly bright.

"I *know* what we saw. But the way me and the rest of us figure it—we don't have a choice. We signed on to be soldiers, and if we desert now, we're stuck in the same boat."

"Geneva says she can protect us—"

"Maybe she can, maybe she can't. That's not the point!"

Daly raked his fingers through his blonde hair. His hands were shaking, but his voice was more controlled when he spoke.

"We may not like what happened, but every bloody bastard out there is higher level than we are. The Captain is right. This is the safest way to level up and learn how to fight. So long as we don't try to run."

"So what? So you'll all gain levels fighting. And then what? Will you join up as a soldier? Keep working here?"

Luan folded his arms. Daly shrugged.

"I haven't thought that far ahead. No one has. But if we *don't* have a way to defend ourselves, what's to stop us from getting shot? Or getting killed like Johanas and the rest?"

He looked meaningfully at Luan as he said that. Ken didn't know what to say, but Luan shook his head.

"Daly, after what I've seen, I don't think any amount of levels or Skills or weapons is enough. Fighting in these wars, with these companies...if I can help it, I'd rather not fight at all. I have something to live for. Someone to live for."

Someone? Ken looked at Luan, and then at Daly as the other young man shook his head.

“I guess that’s the difference in the way we see things. Some days it’s fine to run. Other days you’ve gotta buckle down and fight.”

And that was it. He refused to go, and told Ken and Luan the same went for the rest.

“We’re sticking together on this. Each one of us. We’re a team, and a lot of the others are decent sorts. The Centaurs are right bastards, the Dullahans are stuck up, and the Lizardfolk love killing cute things, but they’re all like us. We’re a company and we’re not going to abandon each other.”

There was something wonderful about what he said, and also...Ken felt drawn to what Daly was saying, but he shared Luan’s horror. And he agreed with Luan. It was one thing to risk his life, but for this? To haul dead bodies away so more people could fight? That was senseless to Ken, more than the call of staying with the company was.

Ken and Luan didn’t just ask Daly of course. Aiko was asking some of the girls she knew, but the answer was the same. The others wouldn’t join up with Geneva, who they’d never met. They were going to stick together, to keep working. They’d been shaken by the executions of that morning, and they had seen the truth in what Quallet had told them. Only one of them had died so far while clearing the undead. But those who had fled had died. True, Johanas and the others had only been a fraction of the American group, but no one, including Ken, thought the others had survived.

In a strangely perverse way, the executions had brought the rest of the Humans, the rest of Gravatender’s Fist closer together. They were a proper company now. Only Luan, Aiko, and Ken couldn’t be part of it.

“We’ll be watching for you lot. If you survive the fighting...well, we’ll see then, won’t we? Watch how you go.”

Daly shook Ken’s hand, as did the others. That left Ken, Luan, and Aiko to march up to Quallet’s tent as night began to fall. Ken wondered if they were doing the right thing. Johanas and the others had fled without a word. What would Quallet do if Ken told him to his face that he wanted to quit?

Stare. That was the answer. The [Mercenary Captain] was getting ready for the night's work. Now he turned and stared at the three.

"If you go, you'll be deserters. You saw what happened to deserters this morning. Why risk it? And why tell me?"

"Because we want to be honest about it."

Luan met Quallet's eye. The Captain eyed him back and nodded to the forest.

"So you'll just run off and pray you don't get spotted by a patrol? Because if you do—"

"No. we will go to the [Doctor]."

Quallet paused.

"The [Doctor]? Why—"

"We know her. She's...from where we are."

The Captain frowned. He looked at Ken, then at Aiko, and then Luan. But it was Ken his eyes settled on, and Quallet remembered his promise to give Ken a bonus. He shook his head.

"I won't stop you. But if you leave my company, you'll be on your own. That [Doctor] seems competent, but she has no company. She's got a handful of soldiers protecting her, and she won't have enough healing potions to do her job forever. Not with the way this war is going. What makes going with her better? She's one person. A single [Doctor]. *Alone.*"

"She's not alone."

Aiko was the one who said it. Ken and Luan closed their mouths and looked at her. She stared at Quallet, eyes still red from crying, but resolute. She spoke carefully, forming the words in English.

"She is not alone. We are like her. We are not...not soldiers. She is like us. She does not kill."

"Neither does my company. We fight undead. We dispose of the dead. What makes her work any different from the work we do?"

"She saves lives."

Luan spoke. Quallet opened his mouth, and then Ken interrupted him. He looked at Quallet, and a slight suspicion made him speak.

“Captain Quallet. May I ask a question?”

“What?”

“You are a smart captain. You are experienced as a leader. You heard us arguing. So...”

Ken hesitated. He looked at Quallet.

“...Did you tell the Dullahans that our friends would try to run away last night?”

Aiko gasped. Luan’s eyes widened. Quallet just stared at Ken, and then he turned away. Ken stared at his back, and then he walked out of the tent.

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Once, Geneva had been terrified for her life. She had been a new recruit in the Raverian Fighters, a soldier; for all that she'd been a [Doctor]. She had faced her worst fears, treating her fellow soldiers and enemies alike. She had...failed...so many times. Failed to save lives.

At some point, that feeling had eclipsed her regard for her own life. She just couldn't muster the same feeling, the same fear of dying as she used to. Everyone was dying. Everyone on the operating table was a life. What did Geneva have to fear from an arrow or a sword in the gut? She faced her worst fear every time she saw light slipping from the eyes of the people she treated.

She had lost her fear. Only, she'd found it again. Now she was afraid. Geneva had woken up after another of Okasha's enforced naps to find three more souls in her camp. Three more bodies among many. Only, these ones were special.

Kenjiro Murata. Aiko Nonomura. Luan Khumalo. Three people from her world. Now, under her care.

Geneva had no idea what to do with them. She had spotted them approaching, waving a white flag, across the edge of the valley. Twice, groups of soldiers had raced towards them and there had been a tense moment where swords had been drawn. Only, Ken had talked them down both times, pointing towards Geneva's camp.

Now they were here, eating food, talking quietly among themselves. They had a haunted, shell-shocked look, that of people who'd seen too much, too quickly. Geneva understood the feeling.

She was talking with Calectus, who oversaw the other Selphids that had volunteered to be her assistants. Geneva had thought it was odd at the time, that so many Selphids should want to help her. But she'd had volunteers from other soldiers before and hadn't had the time to worry about it.

Now she knew it was because the Selphids wanted her to help them. That was fine. Geneva's purpose was to help people. She didn't care. But she wondered if Calectus believed in what she did, or if he thought all her

struggling to save lives was pointless. What did Selphids think about the living, anyways? They inhabited dead bodies. They would have wanted Geneva to fail more often.

But there was a living, mortal compassion in him. Geneva had seen him comforting the wounded, and he had spoken to Ken as well. He had dead eyes, literally. But the thing that used the dead eyes was living. The Selphids understood loss just as much as anyone else. They also understood danger, more acutely than Geneva did. They were soldiers, and knew war.

“These three are deserters, Geneva. They will be killed if they leave your camp.”

Calectus gestured at Luan and the others. Geneva nodded.

“And if they stay in the camp? Can you protect them?”

The Lizardman’s face grimaced.

“As much as I can protect you. You have no company—but you are known as the Last Light.”

“Yes.”

Geneva *hated* that title. The Last Light? It was too fitting, and not at the same time. She was not some kind of quasi-goddess, the guardian who stood between life and death. She was just a [Doctor], and not a fully-trained one at that. If a true heart surgeon had come from her world, or a decent anesthesiologist, or someone who knew how to make—make penicillin or any one of the things Geneva so desperately needed—how many lives could they have saved?

“My reputation is the only thing keeping us alive, is what you’re saying.”

Calectus bared his Lizardman’s teeth.

“That, and the fact that we don’t stray from our camp. I can make sure the three are safe, but that only is true if they stay within the boundaries of the camp.”

Geneva looked around. The ‘camp’ was little more than a collection of tents in a clearing. It was not a large area—a space had been cleared for the wounded to lie on pallets before going into her operating tent. There was a

place for her to sleep, tents for the Selphids and the wounded who would rest, a tent filled with supplies and the healing potions she had, not to mention extra bandages, scalpels, needles...and that was it.

She sighed. It wasn't a good place for people to be cooped up in, but it was better than nothing. She nodded at Calectus.

"Okay. Just...give them space. It's not hard to feed them, and we have room."

He nodded, and Geneva went over to talk with Ken and the rest. They looked up as she approached and smiled at her. Geneva tried again, but a smile wouldn't come out. She stood awkwardly in front of them, aware of the dried blood on her clothing. She didn't know what to say. She hadn't really spoken to anyone for a long time. She just did her job.

"Calectus says you'll be safe, so long as you don't stray. I can't offer you protection outside of the camp and maybe not in it. I'm not part of any company."

She blurted out the details. Luan nodded.

"We understand, and we're grateful for all of this, Geneva. You didn't have to do this. We won't leave the camp."

"I—you're welcome."

It felt strange for him to thank her for anything. Geneva looked around, trying to say something, anything. Condolences for the friends that had been executed? She didn't know their names.

It was Aiko, the young Japanese girl with red eyes who spoke up.

"Um, Miss Geneva-san..."

"What?"

"If you are not a company, why do you have that...flag?"

She pointed and everyone turned to look at the banner over Geneva's tent. Geneva stared up at a crude pole of wood, atop which sagged a white flag with a red cross painted in the center.

"That? It's not a company banner. It's a symbol. I use it to tell soldiers that I'm not a fighter."

Ken stared at it. The banner was too limp in the lack of a breeze for the red cross to be too visible, but he figured it out after a moment.

“The symbol for hospitals. The red cross.”

“It’s also the symbol of the Red Cross organization. They’re an international organization that does...does work like this.”

Geneva had seen the parallel, although she felt like she was stealing the identity of that group with her symbol. Ken nodded excitedly.

“Oh! Yes! I have seen them on the news before. Do people in this world know the symbol?”

“Some have associated it with me. But it’s not something that will protect you.”

“Sort of hard to see.”

Luan commented neutrally. Geneva shrugged. It was a flag. She didn’t need that, but it helped sometimes. She heard a shout and her head snapped around. Someone was running, galloping towards her camp. She saw Ken and the others tense, but it wasn’t soldiers coming for battle.

Four Centaurs raced towards the camp, supporting a fifth Centaur between them. Geneva saw more soldiers rushing behind them, taking the opportunity to find a gap in the fighting and head their way. She raised her voice, turned, and found Calectus striding towards her.

“Calectus, I’m going to triage. I need you to wake up one of the others and get them ready for operating. You lot—”

She turned. Ken, Aiko, and Luan had already backed off to a respectable distance. Geneva nodded at them. The first wounded body came in, a Centaur who was missing a leg and had some kind of javelin buried in his side. It was barbed and would have to be cut out. As Geneva began to work, calling out to Calectus to bring another healing potion, she lost track of her newest guests.

Diagnosis. Incision. Cut away damaged flesh. Suture. Use healing potions. Geneva was grateful for her limited supply of potions. She didn't have much—most of it had been donated to her by people she'd saved, or come from Calectus and the other Selphids. Geneva rationed it, using the dependable sutures where healing potions weren't necessary. She had to stitch people up, save them. Making them well enough to walk out of her camp and keep fighting wasn't her goal.

It was tiring, backbreaking work. Surgery could be as precise as grafting onto a heart, or as crude as sawing through bones. Or sawing through a Dullahan's armor to get to their damaged innards.

Maneuvering a Centaur around on her table was just as hard. Geneva and her helpers had to do lifting at times, and it was just as well that some of Okasha's Skills made Geneva's right arm far stronger than her left. Too, Geneva could concentrate solely on her left hand while Okasha operated her right, as well as her legs if necessary.

Small blessings. Geneva was busy wiping down her table, removing blood, scat, and urine that her latest patient had covered the surface with, when someone timidly entered the tent. Geneva looked up, expecting the next patient, and instead found Aiko.

"Is something wrong?"

"I—"

The young Japanese girl opened her mouth, inhaled the scent of the urine and feces, and gagged. She took a moment to collect herself while Geneva swept it all off the table and washed it all away with soapy water.

"I want to help. I would like to help you. If I can."

Geneva blinked at Aiko. She stared at the young woman's pale face.

"Why?"

Aiko hesitated. She looked at Geneva, and then at the blood on the table and paled, but when she raised her head, there was determination in her eyes.

"I am not brave like Ken or Luan. I...I do not like fighting. But I have been sitting in camp, and I see so many hurt people...I want to help them. Do you think I can?"

Her question struck Geneva in her heart. It was a reflection, an echo of what Geneva had thought as a girl. She stared at Aiko, and then nodded. It wasn't just the determination that swayed Geneva, made her take a chance on Aiko. It was the compassion.

Aiko was breathing heavily as she looked at the blood. She'd been pale-faced staring at the wounded. She looked at Geneva, wavering.

"I am sorry. I know I am a coward—I am afraid of blood and guts—"

Geneva reached out. Her hand was covered in blood and she stopped. But then she reached out and touched Aiko lightly on the shoulder. The girl's eyes turned to the blood, but she didn't flinch away.

"Unwilling to fight doesn't mean 'coward'. If you have the stomach for it, I'd welcome a second pair of hands."

"I will try."

Geneva nodded. Something...she felt like she had met another Okasha, perhaps. Other soldiers had come, the Selphids were able assistants when it came to holding the wounded down, but few had the temperament to be part of the operations, to see the horrific injuries and try to fix them. Perhaps Aiko had what it took, perhaps not. But she could certainly try.

"What should I do?"

What could she do? Geneva blinked, thought for half a second, and then thought of all the things a surgical assistant would do, all the things that Geneva had to do herself.

"Thread the needles, sharpen scalpels...hand me objects. Make sure the healing potion is ready for when I need it. If you can handle the first hour, I'll teach you how to sponge blood away properly and see what else you can do."

She was showing Aiko how to put everything close to Geneva so Okasha could grab it when the tent flap opened and a screaming man came in. He fainted as the Selphids put him on the table. Aiko was shaking, but she didn't run or faint as Geneva inspected the gaping wound in his upper thigh. Geneva nodded to the two Selphids, one a female Dullahan, the other a male Centaur, both with pallid skin.

“They’re here in case the patient wakes up. If they do, back away. I’ve had them try to cast spells, stab me with hidden daggers...we have no anesthesia and they sometimes wake up as I’m cutting into them.”

The words should have terrified Aiko. They would have terrified Geneva had she heard them before she’d come to this world. But the girl had lived on the battlefield at night for over a week now. She’d carried corpses, stabbed undead, risked her life and gone through it all. A coward? No. Cowards ran, froze up, and didn’t act. Aiko could act. Her hand was steady as she held a suture and towel in both hands. Geneva nodded to her.

“Let’s get to work.”

Aiko was brave. Ken knew it, Luan knew it. They sat together, watching bodies enter and leave Geneva’s tent, and both of them thought the same thing. Only Luan gave voice to it.

“Ken, I feel worthless.”

“I feel the same way.”

They saw Aiko appear outside and hurl a bowl of—was it *crap*?—out of the tent. They’d seen her working with blood and worse on her clothes, and yet she was still in there. Helping Geneva save lives.

Ken and Luan weren’t in there. They hadn’t thought of going in and offering to help. When Aiko had said it, Ken had wanted to go in with her. But he couldn’t. He couldn’t face the horror of what he saw outside.

Just the thought of seeing Geneva operate, of watching her slice into someone and being asked to hold them down, or sew something shut filled Ken with mortal dread. He couldn’t do it. It wasn’t just about bravery; it was about being able to look at that without freezing up. Luan couldn’t do it either.

“I’m ashamed to say it Ken, but I feel like we’re useless here. I think we were right not to keep going to Gravetender’s Fist, but...”

Ken nodded. But they were doing nothing *here*, and that was worse. Worse, because when you stopped to stare at what Geneva did, there was no helping but feeling small.

She saved lives. Soldiers came in, wounded beyond belief, carried by friends who begged her to save them. And she did. Sometimes she failed, but Ken had seen bodies go in, pale-faced Humans and Centaurs who he would have sworn were dead come out, weak, but alive.

It was humbling. And more, it made Ken question what he'd been doing. He'd put down dead bodies. Why hadn't he spent his time saving them?

"What can we do to help?"

"I don't know."

Luan shook his head. He was staring at the flag over Geneva's tent again. The red cross was barely visible behind the white folds of the flag. He muttered to himself.

"She really needs a banner. Or a sign."

"Why? So everyone can see?"

"It's a symbol, Ken. It means...it means do no harm. It's one of the most powerful symbols from our world. Everyone should know what it means."

Ken nodded slowly. The red cross. The symbol of hospitals, of an ambulance. Of...life. He understood Luan.

"But there are no more flags."

"We have a white one."

They'd brought the white flag from the Gravetender's Fist company. As Luan had pointed out, they hadn't received any pay, so this was the least of what they were owed. Ken nodded, thinking.

"But it is white. We'd need red paint."

"Or blood...no, we'd need paint."

Luan shook his head, and Ken shook his head as well. Blood was... wrong. And the bugs would probably be attracted to it.

“Where would we get paint?”

“I know where. But I do not know how we would buy it.”

Ken hunched his shoulders as Luan stared at him. The South African young man opened his mouth, frowned, and then felt at his pockets.

“If you need something to sell...what about this?”

He put something in Ken’s hand and warned him not to touch what was inside. Ken opened the tightly-wrapped ball of cloth and recoiled from the small, pointed orange tip of an arrow. Luan’s grin was twisted.

“That’s what Geneva pulled out of me. It’s still active. Magical. I bet you could put it on an arrow and shoot it. I hear they’re expensive. Know anyone who might buy it?”

Ken nodded slowly. He wrapped the arrowhead up and looked at Luan.

“I think I might.”

War vendors were ostensibly [Merchants], but ones who had a huge escort, many items for sale, usually had at least half a dozen bags of holding, and made a living selling to companies that were fighting. They could provide anything from magical potions to weapons to information—all at a steep price.

Ken had seen Quallet negotiating with the sole war vendor in the area to buy food for his company. The neutral zone shared by all three undead suppression companies was adjacent to the war vendor’s zone, although a set of very well-equipped guards patrolled the border.

It was to this area that Ken made his way. It was frightening, not to mention dangerous, going through the valley, even with a white flag, but he’d done it. Alone, too. He’d insisted to Luan it was the best way. In truth, Ken was worried Luan might be hurt. Only one of them needed to risk their lives.

Now Ken approached the war vendor, flanked by two very tall Lizardmen with swords. He spotted the [Merchant] in question in a moment. He was familiar to Ken, although they'd never spoken.

The Naga with golden scales and resplendent jeweled clothing was sinuously twined around what looked like a circular couch, meant for someone just like him. It was more like a spiraling staircase upwards, in truth, with a spot for his more humanoid torso to rest while his snake-like lower body twined around the bottom. He uncurled and rose up, at least nine feet tall as Ken approached.

The Naga was male, although his genitals weren't visible—Ken had no idea where they might be, as the Naga's lower half was like a snake's—and he smiled down at Ken.

“Ah. I have seen your face before, young Human male. Have you come to sell or buy? Or just to look some more?”

He remembered Ken, which was a good sign. Ken gulped and bowed as the guards stepped back from the Naga. He clearly wasn't regarded as much of a threat, because the Naga waved them further back as he eyed Ken up and down.

It wasn't rude to stare at Lizardfolk...and the Naga was apparently what Lizardfolk could become. Quexa hadn't given Ken all the details, but Lizardfolk could change forms like...well, like Pocket Monsters, to be honest. What did Americans call it? Oh, right. Pokémon.

Ken stared at the Naga, giving him a slow look from top to tail in return. The Naga appreciatively wiggled his tail at the scrutiny.

“Ah, you know our customs. You are an interesting Human. What are you called?”

“I am Ken. Thank you for giving me the opportunity to meet with you. May I ask your name?”

Ken bowed his head, and the Naga smiled wider. He spread his arms, showing off bejeweled fingers.

“I'm Xalandrass, inquisitive little Human. But you may call me 'Xal', as I know Humans are not as adept at speaking as other races.”

Ken nodded, and took a breath.

“Honored Xalandrass—”

The Naga laughed in delight. Ken smiled a bit.

“Honored Xalandrass, may I ask if you buy items such as this?”

He took the balled up piece of cloth and unveiled the enchanted arrowhead. Xalandrass peered at it and then smiled knowingly at Ken.

“An Evercut Arrow? Where did you get this?”

“A friend had it.”

“In him? Oh, I heard about that incident. A dangerous thing, when a company attacks the very people they have hired. But then, I share some of the blame. For I sold these arrows to the Roving Arrow company to begin with.”

A part of Ken’s chest tightened at that. Xal watched Ken’s face.

“Do you hold a grudge, little Ken?”

“I do not believe I should blame you, Xalandrass.”

“Ah, but the Honored Xalandrass is gone. Oh well. But to answer your question, yes, I would buy this back from you. It can certainly be reused, so I could offer you gold...but why do I think you have risked your life to come here for more than that?”

Ken nodded. He took a breath.

“I would like to barter with you, *Honored Xalandrass*. For paint. Do you have anything I could use to color with?”

The Naga had begun laughing again, but he stopped. He didn’t look surprised by Ken’s request, merely thoughtful. He tapped his lips with a long finger for a second before nodding.

“Paint? Curious. A Human child comes to me with an enchanted arrowhead, where another came with a device that made light. What does it mean?”

He was watching Ken. Ken kept his face politely blank. Xal smiled knowingly.

“Hm, hmm~. I think we have a deal, little one. Paint I can easily obtain—I have some with me. Dried packets that need only water. It’s a very

handy tool for marking the ground with, and for marking armor. Dullahans love the stuff, so I have every color available. Which would you like?”

“Red, white, and black colors, please.”

“Only that? Anything else? I have many magical artifacts for sale. For the right price, of course.”

Xal flicked his fingers, Ken saw one of the wagons behind him move. Objects floated upwards and around Ken as the Naga gestured to each one, speaking softly, enticingly.

“Here’s one that will shield you from arrows...for a time. Or how about a shield that creates a burst of light when struck? Everyone but you will be blinded. Or what about a charm to amplify your voice? That’s a favorite among commanders like your Quallet Marshhand. My apologies, former commander, isn’t it? I’ve heard you’re with the famous Last Light. What’s *she* like?”

The question came out quick and fast, but Ken was ready for it. He bowed his head politely towards Xal.

“I am sorry, but I came here only to buy and sell. I cannot give information I do not have the right to.”

The Naga smiled, this time with regret.

“Ah, too clever. You came prepared, not at all like the other one. It is enjoyable talking to you, honorable Ken. A shame there is no profit in it. Very well. I will give you paint—and coin, since the paint is not worth an Evercut arrowhead. And you shall go speaking of how fair I am. And then, perhaps when the Last Light needs healing potions or needles, she will send you again, hm?”

Ken smiled politely.

“It is my deepest hope, Honored Xalandrass.”

The Naga laughed.

“Pretty liar.”

The next day, Geneva stumbled out of her tent, a piece of dried jerky in her hands. She had woken to the sound of the wounded. She approached the line of wounded, and paused as she realized something was off.

What was it? Geneva looked around, frowning, and then saw the signs.

Huge sheaves of bark had been peeled from trees, hammered onto slats of wood, and pounded into the ground. A white background with a red cross had been painted on each one, and the signs were ringing the camp, marking it.

But what was most striking was the sign that stood tallest of all. A sign that shook Geneva to her core.

The Red Cross Company.

It was simple, direct, and it spoke to her. She stared up at the sign as it proclaimed...what? That they were a company, a fighting force? One of the many groups in Baleros?

No. That they were something else. The Red Cross. Here. Geneva looked around, and saw Ken and Luan waving at her. They had paint all over their bodies and their hands were red from work.

She looked at them, and felt the urge to smile. It didn't come out, but Geneva inclined her head. Then she got to work.

An incident occurred as Ken and Luan were painting a final sign to put up. They heard a roar and dropped what they were doing to hurry over to a vantage spot to look at the battlefield. There they saw a group of Dullahans, carving through the Centaur's forces.

Ken had seen the battle go back and forth day after day. There was never a clear winner; if one side started pushing too far, more reserves would come flooding onto the battlefield and force the enemy back. It was a war of attrition between both companies, or at least, it had been. Apparently, someone had decided to end things.

Six giants walked across the battlefield, each one at least twelve feet tall. They were Dullahans, only...not. To Ken, it was like seeing a miniature robot warrior, like Gundam, a giant of metal and motion. But they were Dullahans. They had all the features of a Dullahan, only their armor had been scaled up in a massive way.

But their heads were the same size. It would have been ludicrous, with the tiny helmeted heads of the Dullahan on top of the massive, armored bodies, were it not for the deadly way in which the Dullahans controlled these oversized armored titans.

They were quick. And strong. One of the Dullahans lifted a massive greatsword as tall as Ken and *cut* a Centaur apart in a single strike. He roared and charged into the line of Humans and Centaurs and Lizardfolk, and Ken saw blood and limbs and screaming as the five other Dullahans rampaged into the enemy lines with him.

“What *is* that?”

Luan was staring at the Dullahan giants, mesmerized. Ken had no answer, but Calectus came up behind the two and spoke.

“War Walkers.”

The two looked at him. Calectus nodded towards the Dullahan titans, quietly serious.

“They’re one of the most dangerous types of Dullahan warrior on the battlefield. Their class is an advancement of the [Juggernaut] class. If they’re coming out, it means the Razorshard Armor company is determined to win at any cost.”

“And that means what?”

Calectus paused.

“It means Geneva will have more work to do.”

The Dullahan [Juggernauts] inflicted terrible damage onto the Centaurs. Terrible damage...in return for their lives. Ken watched, spellbound, as each of the War Walkers fell after taking down scores of their enemy with them. It was a simple casualty of their size. For all their strength and armor, enchanted weapons could harm them, and the Centaurs galloped around the Dullahans, shooting arrows at them, charging into them with lances...

It was a bloody cost. In the end, the last [Juggernaut] fell as the Centaurs pulled back, sorely devastated. The War Walkers were down...

But not dead.

One of them lived, at least, enough for a group of smaller Dullahans to retain hope. Ken saw them lifting one of their fallen giants up and approach the tent. He shouted for Geneva, who'd finished for the day. The [Juggernauts] left little wounded as they fought.

"We come for aid. Please. Help us."

One of the Dullahans in the group approached as Geneva ran towards them. Ken stared at the massive form of the Dullahan War Walker, supported by twenty of his lesser brethren. He was a true giant, and far too large to stuff into Geneva's operating tent.

He was also on the verge of death. Countless arrow holes filled his body, and his left shoulder was nearly severed from his body. He had lost so much blood it was painting his blue armor. Ken thought there was no way Geneva could save him.

But she didn't hesitate.

"*Aiko!* Start removing armor! The rest of you—show me where he's wounded! Get the armor off of him!"

She began ordering the Dullahans as they spread out around her. Geneva leapt onto the wounded [Juggernaut]'s shoulder and listened as one of the Dullahans explained. He'd been riddled with Evercut arrows, and they were cutting him apart from the inside. Geneva nodded. She knelt by the first wound, where armor had been hacked away, exposing only blood and guts.

"[Flash Hands]. [Flawless Cut]."

Her hands *blurred*. Ken saw the scalpel she was holding disappear in her left hand, and then Geneva was cutting deep, *deep* into the War Walker. Luan hurried over to Ken's side and stopped as he saw Geneva working.

"My god."

Geneva's hands were a mirage of moving afterimages as she cut into the giant Dullahan's flesh. Her left hand cut, her right hand moved flesh aside. She was tracing the path of the arrow, assessing the War Walker's condition. He wasn't going to survive long. Geneva paused, and placed a hand on his chest. She spoke.

"[Hemostatic Pause]."

The blood leaking from his wounds...stopped. Ken heard some of the Dullahans gasp, but Geneva was already speaking.

"I have six minutes and forty seconds. Aiko, I need healing potions and the dropper. The rest of you—point out to me where he was shot!"

She dove back into the Dullahan's body. In moments, she'd pulled out the first Evercut arrowhead and flicked it onto the ground. Ken helped contain it. Geneva was working fast, faster than she had with Luan. The Dullahans were pointing out every wound, and she pulled eighteen more arrows out in minutes. Geneva paused as the last one came out and closed her eyes.

"[Detect Injury]...there's one left. Somewhere in the upper right side of his chest."

She found it. Then she came to the shoulder. Now the [Juggernaut] could be healed, the wounds in his chest were vanishing. But his shoulder was hanging on by a literal thread of flesh. The Dullahan who'd requested Geneva's help looked grim, but resolute.

"His life is all that matters. If the arm must come off—"

"Not yet."

Geneva looked towards Aiko. The Japanese girl had something in her hands that she'd been using to pour the precious liquid into the wounds. A dropper, medieval style. It didn't have a rubber bulb, but it could be used to measure small amounts of the healing potion. Geneva beckoned for it, and then spoke out loud.

“The suturing will take time and full concentration. I need you to hold the arm—and keep it steady. I will reconnect each nerve and muscle and heal it when it is in place.”

“What?”

Luan stared. Ken stared. What Geneva was saying sounded impossible—but then she began.

“Muscle. Connects to...”

Ken saw her right hand move. Geneva stared at it, as if she hadn’t expected where it was going, but then she connected the red piece to the second piece, and dropped a minute bit of healing potion on it. The link formed.

“I’ll need to graft connections. You—open up his leg armor. I’ll need to make an incision—major artery is here...connects...here.”

The work took over an hour. Ken couldn’t watch half of it. But he saw Geneva reconstruct the giant Dullahan’s arm, piece by piece. And when it was done, when the flesh had healed and sealed over entirely, he had seen every part of the arm reconnected. Ken had no doubt that when the War Walker awoke, he would be able to move the arm.

“A healing potion couldn’t have done that. No way. The arm was severed—it can’t heal when that happens. But she put him together. Just like that.”

Luan was staring at Geneva. She’d practically collapsed after it was done, as had Aiko. They were resting, but the Dullahan soldiers were still there. The one who was probably their officer was looking around for someone to talk to, so Ken walked over.

“Thank you. We will report this to our superiors.”

The Dullahan bowed at the waist deeply, like a Japanese businessman meeting his company’s CEO. Ken bowed his head as well.

“I will convey your thanks to Geneva-san.”

The other Dullahans crowded around Ken, speaking the same words.

“Thank you.”

It wasn't right that Ken was the one they spoke to, but it was as if they were transmitting their feeling to Geneva. Some clasped Ken's hand, a gesture he'd never seen among Dullahans. Then they were marching the massive War Walker back towards their camp.

Calectus spoke when they were gone.

"Dullahans *never* bow that low."

He was staring at the direction they'd gone. Ken nodded. The Dullahans had shown more emotion, more deference in that moment than he'd ever seen Xor give Quallet.

"That was extraordinary, wasn't it?"

Calectus hesitated.

"It was impossible. A spell might have saved that Dullahan—but no potion, aside from the ones a Named Adventurer would use. But a single person did that. Geneva did. With her Skills."

He turned, shaking his head.

"It might not have been a good thing to save him. But I could not stop her. She will level from this, I have no doubt. And yet..."

"What?"

Calectus turned to Ken.

"She saved a War Walker, someone deemed dead by his enemies. She changed the battlefield, preserved a part of the Razorshard Armor company's strength. She is no longer a small asset, something that can be ignored. Now she is a powerful ally...or a dangerous enemy."

He looked concerned. And he was right to be. The next day, one of the commanders of the Razorshard Armor company came in person.

The [Commander] in charge of the division of the Dullahan company the War Walker had been assigned to was named Grishka. She had brilliant yellow armor crossed with blue, and it was made of some kind of gleaming

metal that looked too brilliant to be steel. Geneva insulted her in the first moment by refusing to see her until she'd finished with her patient, a wounded Lizardwoman.

When she did have time to speak to the Dullahan, at Ken's panicked insistence, Geneva was direct.

"Commander Grishka, I apologize if my ignorance has caused offense. However, my policy as a medical practitioner is to treat all my patients equally, regardless of rank, gender, or species. I do not discriminate. That means I also do not take sides, or rewards, for the work I do."

The Dullahan lifted her head up with her hands, tilting it from side to side as she regarded Geneva's bloodstained clothing and hands.

"I respect your decision, Human. But your actions have saved one of my most dedicated soldiers, and for that my company owes you thanks. This gift is an expression of that. Will you not take it?"

She had brought a chest full of healing potions and several bags of gold with her. Geneva stared at the gold and looked past it in a moment. But the healing potions kept her eye. She hesitated.

Her position was to be neutral. Inoffensive to either side she tried to help. But at the same time, Geneva knew that her own supplies of potions were limited. And they were practically exhausted from treating the War Walker yesterday. She didn't know whether refusing the gift would be better, and realized she had no choice. It was a simple binary between saving more lives, or not being able to because she had no more potions.

She inclined her head.

"Donations are acceptable. Please know this will not change how I work in any way."

"It is acknowledged. The Razorshard Armor company thanks you for your actions. We will ask your assistance with other soldiers who are wounded."

Commander Grishka spoke formally, and then used her hands to raise her head so she could whisper in Geneva's ear.

"And I thank you personally as well. The War Walker you saved...is my second brother."

She left. Geneva stared at the potions and the gold. She ignored the gold and grabbed a potion.

“Aiko, we’ll test the effects of this before using. Let’s get back to work.”

The Centaur group galloped into camp a day after the incident with Commander Grishka. Luan and Ken were busy creating bandages that could be tightened and used on the wounded who came into camp when a group of Centaurs raced towards them, weapons drawn. They nearly ran over the two and would have stormed right into Geneva’s operating tent had Calectus not stopped them with his halberd.

“Our [Captain] was wounded in battle! Help her!”

The lead Centaur, a brash, tall roan with chestnut hair and wild, long locks shouted at Geneva as she came out of her tent. He and his friends had their weapons drawn, and they were protectively encircling a Centaur whose belly had been cut open. Her entrails were being held in place by another Centaur’s hand.

“Put down your weapons! Violence is not welcome here!”

Geneva snapped up at him. The lead Centaur snarled and darted towards her, stopping only when Calectus swung his halberd in the way.

“*Help* her!”

Geneva gestured back into her tent, where her current patient, a Dullahan, was screaming.

“I have a patient I have to attend to first—”

“*Now!* Or I will cut your guard down and everyone else in this camp!”

The Centaur was practically mad with emotion. His friends were restraining him with difficulty. Geneva grew very still and spoke calmly.

“Threatening me or anyone in this camp will not save your [Captain].”

“She is my *mother*.”

That stopped Geneva. She stared at the pale Centaur with long hair, and then at the Centaur who'd threatened her. Geneva stepped towards her and inspected her. She nodded slowly.

"She is savable, but there are five patients that will die immediately without my help."

"You would put her life ahead of—"

"I do not take sides."

Geneva snapped up at the Centaur, making him back down a step. She looked at the others.

"I will save your [Captain] if I can. I will do everything in my power to save her. But I can save other lives first. You will wait with her over there—my assistant will tell you how to keep her stable in the meantime. But you will wait and if you threaten or harm anyone in my camp, I will not help her."

She met the Centaur's eyes.

"I am a [Doctor]. I am on everyone's side and no one's side. Do you understand?"

He wavered. Geneva walked back into her tent. She saved the Dullahan's life, failed to save two others who came after him. She saved the rest, and the [Captain]. When it was done, the Centaurs stood around their Captain, who had the strength to actually stand and move, however weakly. Geneva had told her to rest, but the Centaurs were adamant they had to bring her back to their camp. It would not be safe to leave her here, they told Geneva.

The son of the [Captain] cantered over to Geneva with Calectus watching warily. He stared down at her, and then awkwardly knelt in front of her. He had tears in his eyes when his mother had walked out of the operating room.

"I will remember this."

Then he got up and raced with his companions out of the camp. Geneva watched him go. The next day, a gift came from the Roving Arrow Company. It was twice as much gold as the Dullahans had given her, and another crate of valuable potions.

“A gift? More like a bribe.”

Calectus shook his head over the gold and the potions, for all they were welcome. There was no returning them either—the Centaurs had dropped the money and potions in the camp and departed without so much as a word. Ken understood the meaning behind it, although Geneva did not.

“Why did they give me more? And why bribe me? I told them I wouldn’t take sides.”

Luan explained for her as he and Ken helped sharpen some of the tools Geneva used to cut into her patients.

“The way the Centaurs see it, if they offer the same amount as the Dullahans or more, you’ll be more inclined to *stay* neutral.”

Geneva shook her head, troubled by the politics of it all.

“I have to stay neutral. And they have to understand it.”

Ken was about to suggest that he go to each company and explain just that when he heard a series of rapid, urgent horn calls from the battlefield. He and the others knew that spelled trouble and all of them were on their feet at once.

Only this time, the trouble didn’t come from the ground. Calectus was the first to spot the two figures falling from the sky, because he’d been looking for them. His voice was loud in the silence as everyone looked up.

“Air strike. [Mages].”

They were *flying*. It caused a hush across the battlefield as soldiers looked up and saw the two figures falling out of the clouds, and then flying across the battlefield. They were both wearing robes which shimmered with magic and fluttered in the wind. Calectus could identify their company at a glance.

“That’s the Tripartite Law company. It’s a three-person company that specializes in mass area of attack spells.”

“There’s only two of them.”

Calectus’ face was dark.

“Two is more than enough. I recognize them. Up there, that’s the Firebringer, Zalthia Werskiv. And the Plague Locust, Embrim Thrus.”

“Zalthia?”

Geneva started. Ken looked at her.

“Do you know her?”

Geneva’s face was pale.

“I’ve met her before. She burned half a forest down and slaughtered the Raverian Fighters. If she’s here—”

“The Roving Arrow company has her contract. They’re trying to end this now. She’s going to hit the battlefield—”

A roar engulfed Calectus’ words as Zalthia Werskiv shot a pillar of flame downwards. It was so sudden, so abrupt, that Ken only felt the impact as a rush of hot air blasted him and the others in the camp. His eyes were searing, and when he looked again—

A huge hole of scorched bodies had appeared in the center of the Dullahan’s formations. Around the area of death, soldiers ran screaming, bodies aflame. Still more fell, choking, as the hot air and smoke suffocated them. In one moment, the Dullahans were retreating; the few who were still upright helplessly shooting arrows at Zalthia and watching them swerve away.

But then the Plague Locust, Embrim Thrus moved. He opened his hand, and a black mist swept downwards. It covered the entire western wing of the battlefield, hitting the soldiers who hadn’t been touched by Zalthia’s fire. Ken saw people clawing at their throats, Lizardfolk trying not to breathe, Dullahans throwing their heads to try and get clear of the mist—breathing—falling.

“Gas attacks. Chemical warfare. Or this world’s equivalent.”

Luan’s face was pale. Geneva was just staring. Ken stared as the [Mages] flew higher, their work done. The battlefield had been turned over

in an instant. The Centaurs were cheering, shooting at their foes, but they were retreating.

“Why?”

Calectus replied.

“It’s too dangerous for them. The mists still linger. When it dissipates, they’ll fight again.”

His words were prophetic. The mists lingered for over ten minutes. When they were gone, the burnt soldiers and ones who had gotten clear of the worst of the gas were still on the ground, dying. But the Dullahans had pulled up more forces and they met the Centaurs in another clash of bodies.

The fighting hadn’t slowed. In fact, it had grown fiercer as the Dullahans tried to exact vengeance on the Centaurs who were pressing their advantage. But that wasn’t what the people in Geneva’s camp saw.

“They’re dying.”

The soldiers who’d inhaled part of the mists, the gas, were choking, suffering. They weren’t dying, but they couldn’t move. Both sides ignored them, too focused on the enemy to worry about helpless victims of the attack. And the burn victims—they were screaming for aid.

“They won’t come here. Not for hours.”

Calectus predicted as Geneva strode back towards her tent. Some of the wounded were already trickling in, but only a few. The majority were stuck out there, unable to be rescued.

Helpless.

And that wasn’t right.

The feeling rose up in Ken, hot and fierce. He was just *standing here*, while Geneva and Aiko worked to save lives. But they couldn’t do anything for the people out there. No one could. They were being left to die, with both sides too occupied to go out and help them!

“Ken.”

Luan put his hand on Ken’s shoulder. He was looking at the wounded, the same helpless fury and desperation on his face. But he’d seen what Ken

was thinking and had stopped him.

“It’s suicide, mate. If we go out, we’ll get shot. We’re deserters, remember?”

“No we’re not. We have a company.”

Ken pointed to the flying red banner. It was flapping in the wind caused by Zalthia’s spell. The red cross flew high. They were the Red Cross company. It wasn’t just a name.

“But they don’t know that. In there—even if we had a flag, we look like everyone else.”

Luan was speaking sense. A soldier was a soldier, and there were Humans on both sides. Ken clenched his fists.

“But—”

“The only people who are safe in this kind of thing are...are people like the Gravetender’s Fist company at night.”

Luan shook his head as he stared across the valley. Gravetender’s Fist had to worry about this issue, but they solved the problem by being a target. They carried lanterns, made noise, had a banner with an illumination spell sewn into the fabric—all so that people knew they weren’t the enemy. Even that didn’t work all the time.

“We can’t do anything, Ken. We’ll just be targets.”

“Targets.”

Ken paused. He stared at Luan. Targets. He’d studied about World War II. It wasn’t a popular subject in Japanese curriculums, if it was taught at all, but Ken had studied it in university and read western textbooks as well as Japanese ones. He’d seen pictures of people who wore targets every day.

“Ken. What are you thinking?”

Luan stared at Ken, looking worried. Ken looked at Luan. The young man still had some of the leather armor he’d been issued. So did Ken. It was dirty, brown, closer to black, and could probably do with polishing.

“Or paint.”

“Paint?”

He stared at Luan, and then at the cans of red and white paint that Aiko had used to decorate the camp. Then Ken looked at the flags. White and red. A target. A symbol.

“Luan, I have an idea.”

“Does it involve us risking our lives?”

Ken nodded. Luan blew out his cheeks. Then he looked at the battlefield, at the wounded.

“It is worth dying for?”

“Nothing is worth dying for. But this—this is worth living for.”

Ken grabbed Luan and dragged him towards the paint.

Daly was sitting, watching the fighting with the rest of Gravetender’s Fist while he ate in preparation of the night’s work. He was dreading it. No one could have missed the air raid by the [Mages], and the bodies were littering the valley floor. But work was work. He adjusted his belt, and looked across the ranks of his company.

Quexa, the Lizardgirl with the [Sorcerer] class was sitting next to Paige. They’d become friends ever since Ken had left. The Lizardgirl hadn’t understood why Ken, Luan, and Aiko had left. In explaining their feelings to her, she and Paige had gotten to know each other.

Now the Lizardgirl was watching the violence below, tail twitching. Daly understood the feeling. You could get used to the death, but never comfortable with it. It was always—

“What the fuck?”

Paige stood up. She’d seen something. Daly’s head snapped back to the battlefield. His mouth dropped open.

“What are those idiots *doing*?”

Two figures had suddenly charged onto the valley floor. They stood out at once, partly because of the flag they were waving desperately and partly

because of their armor.

It was white. Pure white, only there was a stripe of red crossed with another stripe on their shoulders, chest, helmet, and back. It took Daly a second to recognize it.

“A red cross? Are they...medics?”

“What are they doing?”

Quexa had spotted them. She leapt up, full of fear and Daly’s stomach twisted into a knot as he saw soldiers from both sides take notice of Ken and Luan. He saw Luan plant the flag in the ground, and then Ken raised something. A shield. It had the same cross of red on it.

And the soldiers saw it too. They hesitated. They watched as Ken and Luan sprinted away from the flag, and straight into the area that had been blasted by Zalthia. They ran towards one of the fallen soldiers, armor black with soot, and lifted him up.

“I don’t believe it.”

“What? What are they doing?”

Quexa shook Daly as he stared down at Ken and Luan. They had a stretcher of some kind, and they were easing the burnt soldier onto it. As he watched, they lifted it up and began to *run* back towards the camp they’d come from.

“No way!”

Paige was on her feet. Ken and Luan were carrying the wounded soldier, running for all they were worth as arrows flew around them. A group of soldiers broke off towards them, and froze as they saw what Ken and Luan were doing.

The rest of Gravatender’s Fist had noticed what was going on. Daly saw one of the Centaurs rear up in surprise, and then a girl from Bosnia shouted.

“Look! That’s Ken and Luan!”

Both armies had noticed the two insane young men by now. Daly saw a flight of arrows land behind Luan, and then saw the commander shouting at the archers. His heart was pounding. Would they stop firing? Ken and Luan had to run faster!

He leapt to his feet and cupped his hands to his mouth.

“Go! *Run you bastards!*”

He was far too far away to be heard of course. But other people heard him and took up the call.

“*Run Ken! Run Luan!*”

“*Get out of there!*”

“*Run you slow sods! RUN!*”

Soldiers were turning. A group of Centaurs on the battlefield raced towards Ken and Luan and broke away at the last second. Now all of Gravetender’s Fist was cheering and shouting, and the noise was spreading to the other companies.

Heads turned. Ken and Luan raced towards the flag they had planted, and then Daly saw a group of soldiers running to meet them. They grabbed the stretcher and Ken and Luan reversed direction. The soldiers, Selphids, ran back with the burnt soldier towards camp and Ken and Luan ran *back* towards the fighting.

“Other way! *Other way!*”

Some people were shouting that. But now Daly knew what they were doing, and he saw Ken and Luan running towards a Lizardman who’d been trampled. He was clear of the immediate fighting and the two loaded him onto another stretcher.

“Medics! They’re *medics!*”

Daly shouted at Quexa, who looked at him, uncomprehending. No one from her world had a word for what Ken and Luan were doing. Saving soldiers was one thing, but who would run into the fighting and out each time?

Heroes.

Daly shouted. He waved his hands, screamed at Ken and Luan as they raced across the battlefield. The soldiers were fighting around him, but they saw the red cross and didn’t attack.

Why? Did they remember that sign as the symbol of the Last Light? Had their commanders told them to avoid fighting? Were Ken and Luan just not a threat? Or did they see what they were doing?

It was impossible to say. But Daly watched, heart pounding, as Ken and Luan made six more trips out into the chaos, finding the wounded on the edges of the fighting. They didn't run into the heart of the battle. They stayed to the most distant peripherals, finding those who cried out for help.

And they ran with every bit of energy they could. Their lives were on the line. They raced across the broken ground as Gravetender's Fist shouted at them from their position above. The Humans were cheering, shouting and screaming at the two figures as they sprinted towards the downed Lizardman with the stretcher.

"Incredible."

Daly looked over and saw Etredda, one of the most senior Dullahan soldiers, staring at the battlefield. He nodded to her, and she walked over.

"What did you call them? Medics? Is that a class?"

"If it wasn't before, it is now."

Daly knew that in his heart. He knew the two would have the class the instant they slept. Etredda looked at him curiously.

"They are brave. Is that a thing Humans do? Save each other? Save the wounded?"

"Not all Humans. But it's what we used to do. We still do it."

"There is no sense to it."

Etredda shook her head. Daly nodded. The Dullahan nodded as well.

"But there is something noble about it. Foolish, and noble."

"Yeah."

Daly was smiling. He stared at Luan as he and Ken collapsed by their camp. He couldn't see too well from here, but he thought they were laughing.

"It's crazy. But I guess they thought it was worth dying for."

Dying. Geneva stared down at the coughing, gasping Human on her operating table. He was trying to breathe, trying to inhale past the magical mists that had scarred his throat and lungs. He looked up at her, begging for help.

And she couldn't help him. Geneva had never been trained to handle gas attacks. She had none of the experience she needed to help him, and she had no tools.

Gas attacks. Chemical weapons, or this world's equivalent. They had been banned since World War II. The ban hadn't held, but it had been imposed because of just how deadly gas could be.

Deadly, and ineffectual. Geneva's uncle was a history buff and he had lectured her about how gas attacks weren't as useful when both sides had become aware of the dangers and issued gas masks. Allied soldiers could still gun down their opponents while gas floated around them.

Yes, ineffectual. The words were a mockery to Geneva now as she watched the soldier before her suffer. Ineffectual if you had the proper ways of preventing it. But if you *had* inhaled the gas—what could Geneva do?

The effects of this were similar to mustard gas, *for which there was no known treatment*. The best way to deal with it was to avoid exposure—or decontaminate. Geneva snapped out of her trance and looked at Aiko. The girl's face was pale as she stared down at the young man whose skin was already blistering.

“What can we do Geneva...?”

Geneva's hands moved. She began slicing clothes off the soldier, removing his armor. She had a rag mixed with charcoal over her face, and she was going to relocate outside to give the soldier as much clean air as possible.

“Wash their skin with soap and water. If they've inhaled the gas, we'll make them gargle water. They need pure, clean air. We could bleed them to reduce their blood pressure, but I don't have... I don't have...”

She had nothing she could use. Nothing at all. Geneva did everything she could. She washed the soldier's skin, tried to bleed him to lower blood pressure—but he couldn't breathe. And she had no respirator, no way of helping. The gas had vanished far faster than mustard gas, but the effects were permanent.

The soldier died as Geneva helplessly watched. He wasn't the only one. The next soldier who came in had the same afflictions. And the next. Geneva couldn't take it. She left the tent after trying to open the last soldier's airways and found Ken and Luan.

They were grinning, exhausted, covered in sweat, their freshly-painted armor running slightly in the heat. They had carried the soldiers here. Geneva stared at them. They had saved the soldiers, brought her ones she could save. She didn't want to say what she had to.

"Geneva-san! How did we—"

"You can't bring me any more gas attack victims. I can't help them."

Ken's smile vanished. Luan sat up.

"What's wrong?"

Geneva's hands were shaking. She raised them, let them drop.

"There's nothing I can do. *Nothing*. The gas is in their lungs. They can't breathe and I can't save them. If you bring them back here, all I can do is let them die. You cannot rescue them. I can't give them treatment, and there are other soldiers I can save. Do you understand?"

They stared at her. Ken opened his mouth.

"But—"

Luan grabbed him, shook his head. Geneva put her hands to her eyes. The world was swimming. She hadn't cried about the dead before. But now

—

"I can't do anything."

"We understand."

Luan was the first to speak. He got Ken up, nodded to Geneva. There was an echo of the pain she felt in his eyes, but he was taking charge.

“We’ll find others. Come on, Ken.”

He took Ken away. Ken’s eyes followed Geneva. She felt like they were accusing. She watched Ken and Luan head back to the battlefield, risking their lives to save others. Geneva clenched her hands together, helpless.

She squeezed her hands tightly until Okasha made her stop. When Geneva looked down, she saw her untrimmed nails had cut into her skin. She watched the red droplets fall onto the jungle floor, and then went back into her tent and continued operating until every last one of the gas attack victims had died.

There was no glory in this. No brilliance. The elation Ken had felt at saving lives had vanished. Now he ran, heart pounding out of his lungs, desperate. Guilty.

Geneva had wept. She couldn’t save them. Ken skidded to a halt with Luan as he heard a desperate cry. He saw a soldier, a young Dullahan woman crawling towards him, pushing her head across the ground. He started towards her, and then realized she was a gas victim. Her skin was blistering, her eyes damaged.

“Ken.”

Luan looked at Ken, and there was mortal horror in his eyes. Ken looked at the young Dullahan and turned. He heard her call out weakly.

“Wait. Please.”

“I’m sorry.”

Ken stared at her. Luan turned away, choking. Ken turned. He saw more wounded up ahead. Burn victims. Those he could save. He heard the Dullahan cry out desperately. Ken turned his head.

“I’m sorry!”

The next person they found was a Dullahan, male this time. His skin was so badly burned that they could barely touch him. They had to, and he

cried out as they put him in the stretcher. But as they ran back to the camp, he was sobbing in relief. He clutched at Ken as Ken handed him off to the Selphids.

“Thank—thank you.”

The Dullahan looked Ken in the eye as Ken arranged his head next to his body. Ken looked at him, and remembered Johanas’ face as the executioner held the axe over his head. He nodded without words and stood up.

They went back in twice more, Luan and Ken. Then they collapsed, too tired to move. Ken stared at Luan, Luan stared at Ken. The laughter they’d shared after saving their first soldier was gone. But Luan sat up and held out a hand.

“Worth living for.”

Ken took it.

“Yes.”

They saw the burned Dullahan they had saved among the living. That was enough. Ken collapsed into his bed and cried and laughed at the same time.

[Medic Class Obtained!]

[Medic Level 4!]

[Skill – Quick Sprint obtained!]

[Skill – Sympathetic Ear obtained!]

—

“You are rescuing far more Dullahans than Centaurs.”

That was the only thing the Centaur messenger said to Geneva three days later, after he’d galloped into the camp. She was busy working, but he had insisted upon speaking with her. Now that Luan and Ken were working

with several of her Selphids to find the wounded on the edges of the battlefield, she had a steady stream of patients. They knew what to look for as well. Some soldiers could be saved.

But not all of them. And their actions had consequences, although Geneva would never have asked them to stop. She stared calmly back at the Centaur who was glaring at her and replied simply.

“We try to save everyone.”

“But you rescue more Dullahans than Centaurs.”

“Centaurs are heavier.”

It was the plain truth. For as heavy as a Dullahan could be in full plate armor, they were still far less heavy than a Centaur, which was a horse *and* half of a person fused together and possibly wearing armor as well. Even with a group of four, the [Medics] could barely transport a single Centaur while arrows and magic were falling around them.

Still, the truth wasn't enough sometimes. The messenger's eyes narrowed.

“We are watching you. Save Dullahans if you will, but your impartiality seems biased towards them.”

He whirled without giving Geneva a chance to speak and galloped away. She was troubled by that confrontation and spoke to Ken and Luan when they came back.

“Try to save whoever's closest. That's all we can do.”

That evening, a group of armed Centaurs rode into camp. They'd come for all of their wounded, and insisted on taking them all back to their camp. There was no stopping them, for all Geneva argued that the wounded needed to rest and would be safe here.

The Centaurs left, with their escort of warriors watching the woods warily as their wounded limped or were carried back to their camp. Geneva watched them go. She was worried.

So was Luan.

“Escorts now? What happens if the Dullahans send an escort at the same time the Centaurs do?”

“I run out and stop them from fighting.”

He laughed. Geneva did not. The next day, the Dullahans began sending escorts as well. They never clashed with the Centaurs since the Dullahans arrived in the morning and the Centaurs at night. But she felt it was only a matter of time.

Six days after Ken and Luan had begun acting as [Medics], they were interrupted on their way back from the battlefield. A group of eight Centaurs appeared and cornered them and the two Selphids that Ken and Luan had gone out with.

None of them were armed. That was for the best, because the Centaurs were armed. They surrounded Ken and Luan as the [Medics] raised their hands.

“We’re not warriors. We’re trying to save your friends—”

“Save the Dullahans, more like.”

The Centaurs closed in. Ken and Luan looked around, suddenly worried. One of the Centaurs tore the flag that the Selphids were carrying away and hurled it to the ground. Luan turned, outraged.

“Hey! What’re you—”

A club knocked him to the ground. Ken cried out and ran for Luan, but a blow caught him on the back of the head. He fell and heard the Centaur leader bark an order.

The Centaurs began trampling over the fallen. Ken felt a hoof come down on his hand and shouted in agony. Something kicked him so hard he heard a *crack* and the world went dark and sound and feeling became one drumming whirl of agony.

“Ken! Ken! Answer me, man!”

He was conscious of someone shaking him awake. Luan was kneeling over Ken, trying to get him to wake up. Ken opened his eyes, and Luan and

the two Selphids dragged him back towards the camp.

Ken had a concussion. Luan had several bad cuts and a cracked rib. Both Selphids had broken bones—the Centaurs seemed to have focused their anger on them. Both needed new bodies, which wasn't an issue, but the attack was.

Geneva banned Ken and Luan from going out for the rest of the day and tomorrow. Neither Ken nor Luan objected.

“I can ask to talk with their commander. But I can't promise you'll be safe. None of us are safe. We can only appeal to both side's sense of morality and hope they respect what we're trying to do.”

Appeal to their morality. Ken had to have Luan repeat the phrase several times until he understood it. When he did, it didn't reassure him. Morality in Baleros was...unreliable. Could you really appeal to the commanders of both companies? Ken doubted it, no matter what Geneva said.

Perhaps it would work in America, or other parts of the world. It might even work for the Centaurs. They were honorable—they took pride in not committing shameful actions. An ambush to them was not shameful, nor other forms of surprise attacks; that was simply a good way of fighting wars. But Dullahans—

They gave Ken an uneasy feeling in his stomach. They reminded him of how the soldiers of Japan were said to have fought, once. The Dullahans didn't think of things like honor when it came to war in the same way Centaurs did. Suicide attacks, traps, killing prisoners, it was all to win. It reminded Ken of an American expression. A Japanese ideal. What was it? Oh, yes.

Victory at any cost.

And while Centaurs were committed to the idea of honor, it only lasted so long as they thought the *other* side was playing by the same rules. If they thought there was just a hint of underhandedness, there went the need for honor as well. The beating had been a warning. Play fair or we will kill you.

He wished he knew what he could do. But there was no good answer, and in the meantime the battle between the Centaurs and Dullahans had entered its final stages. Both sides had dealt each other terrible blows, and

now the fighting was at its fiercest. It sometimes rampaged into the night, forcing the undead suppression companies to stay where they were rather than get caught up in it.

Dullahans mounted night attacks and Centaurs attacked at all hours. Gravetender's Fist and the other companies had to stay in close proximity to one another to stay safe. It was getting worse and worse, and Ken had seen soldiers start to stab the enemy's wounded rather than let them get to Geneva. But she refused to leave and kept working.

It was the sixteenth day since Ken had reached the battlefield when it happened.

"I won't go Okasha. Not yet."

Geneva was arguing with Okasha again. It had started four days ago, and the Selphid had grown more relentless day after day. She wanted Geneva to abandon the camp, to leave the battlefield where the Razorshard Armor company and Roving Arrow company seemed determined to destroy each other at last. But Geneva couldn't do it.

"There are countless wounded coming in each day. I can't just abandon them—"

"It is growing less safe, Geneva. We don't have the soldiers to protect you if we're attacked."

"If we're attacked, it means my status as a [Doctor] is meaningless, Okasha. I have to trust that my neutrality will be respected."

"Trust."

Okasha said the word as if it was foreign. She shook Geneva's head.

"This is not your world, Geneva. Both companies have shown that they are willing to do whatever it takes to win. And that means you and your friends from another world may be targets again. Please, leave. I can talk to my people; find you a safer place to work. They could guard you—"

“And what will happen if I take their side, Okasha? Should I enlist in their company and start healing only Selphids?”

Geneva snapped and Okasha fell silent. Geneva felt guilty, but she went on.

“I can’t take sides. Even your side. The moment I do, I lose the only thing that protects me. I need to help everyone.”

“But our world isn’t like yours. We aren’t—we don’t obey rules of war, Geneva. Magical gas attacks, attacking civilians—some [Strategists] will do anything for victory.”

Geneva knew that was true. She lowered her head.

“Something has to be the same. Something has to be. If there’s no hope for basic decency between enemies, the faintest belief in the rights of others...then what hope is there?”

Okasha had no answer. Geneva would have argued with her more, but a group of wounded soldiers came in. Dullahans, all comatose. The group of Humans who’d brought them had no idea what was wrong.

“I think—they were hit by a [Sleep] spell. Or something. But they won’t *wake up*. Can you—can you check on them? Make sure they’re alright?”

“I will.”

They could be tended to later. Geneva had no good way to deal with magic, but she was content to let them rest so long as they didn’t show other symptoms. Besides, she had to deal with a group of wounded Lizardfolk that were due to leave with the Dullahan escort this morning.

The escort of armed warriors that came for the Razorshard Armor company’s wounded was three times as large as last time. Geneva frowned when she saw that, but didn’t object. The Dullahan in charge nodded to her as his men began to trek back to his camp. They’d gotten fifty feet away from her camp when she heard the frantic horn calls. They were the same ones she’d heard now and again.

Air raid.

Geneva looked up at the sky, expecting to see one of the two Tripartite Law company [Mages] descending over the valley floor. Instead, she saw a

woman flying down.

Straight at her.

Geneva's heart stopped. She saw Zalthia Werskiv heading straight towards her, hands aglow with fire magic. She was coming for Geneva?

No. The [Doctor] realized what was happening too late. She ran forwards, towards the departing escort of Dullahans, shouting, waving her arms.

"No. No! Stop!"

She screamed up at Zalthia, the Firebringer. The [Mage] flew down as the Dullahans cried out and loosed arrows up at her. Some were turning to flee, others blowing on their horns desperately. Geneva ran towards them, trying to get in the way, to stop Zalthia.

Too slow. A fireball fell from her hand, like a fiery meteor towards the earth. The shockwave flung Geneva back. When she got up, she saw only smoking ash. The escort had been obliterated.

She looked up. Zalthia looked down at Geneva. Was there a smile on her lips? She pointed past Geneva.

At her camp. The Firebringer flew past Geneva, conjuring fire from her hands again. She strafed Geneva's operating tent, throwing a ball of fire that exploded and set the damp canvas ablaze. Then she shot a stream of fire from her hands, raking across the sleeping tents. And the supply tent.

Geneva saw the tent containing the healing potions, her bandages, all of it, go up in a blue and green fireball of twisting colors. Zalthia paused as she saw the magical conflagration and then decided her work was done. She flew off into the air, leaving the camp ablaze.

"No."

She couldn't believe it. The Centaurs had paid her to attack Geneva's camp. Geneva's legs buckled. She sat. Her mind was whirling. Where was Aiko? She was...she'd been with the wounded. She might be safe. Ken and Luan were out looking for people. They were safe. But the camp?

"Gone."

A voice spoke quietly in Geneva's ears. Okasha did not gloat. There was sadness in her voice.

"I warned you. This world is not yours, Geneva. There is no mercy here. No quarter. Your world is gentler, nobler, I think."

Geneva stared at the burning camp. She felt something wild, hysterical, bubbling up inside her. She laughed.

"No. It's the same. The exact same."

The same as the worst of her world. How could she have thought it would be otherwise? They bombed a hospital. Just like her country had. They attacked the wounded. Just like they did during the war. Every war. Snipers shooting medics.

It was exactly the same.

Geneva didn't know when she started laughing hysterically, only that she couldn't stop. She sat in the dirt and laughed, parts of her clothing burning, her operating tent and the camp burning before her eyes as smoke drifted up through the jungle canopy. She only stopped when she heard a voice.

"There's the [Doctor]."

She turned. A Dullahan was looking at her. One of the Dullahans that had been brought in, apparently asleep. He was holding a sword. In a moment, Geneva knew why he was here.

The blade was red. The bodies of the wounded soldiers lined up in front of her tent—Geneva stared at a motionless Centaur's form and then the Dullahan.

"Why?"

He had no words to answer her, but he strode towards her. Geneva didn't move, but Okasha did. She made Geneva leap to her feet and run. But there were more than one of the Dullahan assassins in the camp.

Another leapt out at her. Okasha, using Geneva's body, whipped out one of Geneva's scalpels and cut him along the face. He cried out and Okasha tried to plunge the wickedly sharp blade through his eye. Geneva's hand shot out—

And stopped.

“No.”

Geneva caught her right arm. She heard Okasha cry out, felt the Selphid try to override her. Geneva didn't let her. She clamped down on every muscle in her body, overriding Okasha's desperate attempts to move with sheer will.

“I swore an oath.”

The Dullahan was cursing. Geneva turned and saw the first one striding towards her. It wasn't a he after all, but a she. The Dullahan had dark red armor and a shortsword in one hand.

“What oath?”

She looked at Geneva curiously. Geneva spread her arms wide. She felt her world melting around her. Despair was in her heart.

“I will do no harm. I will not let my patients come to harm. I will do what I can to save lives.”

“Noble.”

The female Dullahan nodded. She looked at Geneva and shook her head.

“But flawed. This is war. And in war, we do what we must.”

She ran Geneva through, blade plunging into her stomach. Geneva gasped, stumbled back, and fell. The Dullahan stabbed her in the stomach twice more, and then bent. She cut Geneva's throat and turned away.

“There's one more. The helper. Find her. Kill her. The two [Medics] don't have their Skills. Let's go before that damn Selphid gets to us.”

The other Dullahan nodded and the two moved off. They ran as Geneva lay on the ground, blood pooling on the ground as her camp—and her cause—burned down around her.

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Kenjiro's grandfather had died the year Ken went into university. He had been 88 years old at the time. Ken had fond memories and bitter memories of his grandfather, many having to do with how his father and grandfather used to bring up old arguments when they met.

They came from two different generations. Ken's father had been born after World War II. His grandfather...had lived through it. He had been fifteen when Japan surrendered. When Ken was little, and when he was growing up, his grandfather would sometimes tell Ken stories of living through the last year of the war, when U.S. planes would drop bombs across Japan.

There was little guilt in his grandfather's eyes for the war. Japan had fought, and it had lost. America had dropped its bomb to end all bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Now there was peace. But there would always be a bit of hatred in Ken's grandfather. Not just for the bomb, but for the nights he'd spent staring up at the sky as bombs fell.

Ken remembered how his grandfather's hands shook, recalling the days when fire would rain down from the skies. It had seemed like all of Tokyo was aflame, at times. Now Kenjiro wondered if this is what his grandfather had seen.

Fire. Geneva's camp was aflame. The mage, Zalthia, the Firebringer, had set it on fire. But that wasn't all.

"Ken. *Ken!*"

Someone was screaming at him. Ken looked around. His head felt empty. His ears were ringing from the explosions. He realized he was standing around aimlessly as Luan charged over to him. He had a mace in his hands. He was bleeding.

"Luan-san."

"Ken! We've got to get out of here! There are soldiers in the camp! They're killing the wounded!"

Ken stared at Luan. He was in shock. He trotted after Luan as the South African young man cursed and shoved at Ken, getting him towards a patch of trees. Ken stared back at the tents. Everything was on fire. The [Mage] had set fire to every bit of the camp. Nothing would be left; the flames were too strong to fight. She'd hit the operating tent. Why? What harm could Geneva have done? What could Aiko—

He blinked. A part of Ken woke back up.

“Aiko!”

He looked at Luan. The older young man—no, the man's face was gray with the horror of what he'd seen, but he was holding his mace, ready to fight. Ken looked around.

“Where's Aiko? Luan, did you see—”

“I don't know. She might have been in the tent—hold on, Ken!”

Ken didn't listen. He raced towards the burning operating tent, halting only when he heard the sounds of fighting. It was coming from the camp, and Luan, running after Ken, stopped when he heard it too.

“An attack?”

Ken looked at Luan. The man hesitated.

“Maybe. The airstrike was one thing. Maybe they sent people to make sure we're all dead? Come on, let's see. Be ready to run or fight!”

Creeping around blazing tents, flinching from the heat, Ken and Luan finally saw what was going on. A group of warriors was struggling amid the burning wreckage. Dullahans and a lone Lizardman that Ken recognized.

Eight Dullahans were fighting a lone figure in the center of the camp. Each Dullahan was armed with a weapon, and they were fighting in unison. Their movements were precise, and Ken and Luan knew any one of them could have killed both Humans in a moment.

But the enemy they were battling didn't fall, despite half of his body being burned black and the numerous wounds he had taken. Calectus snarled, his Lizardman's body twisting and lashing out with his long halberd. A Dullahan with a shield blocked the blade and stumbled back; Ken saw the shield *deform* from the impact.

“Calectus-san!”

Ken whispered. Luan nodded. His face was pale.

“I—I don’t know if jumping in will help or not. They’re moving too fast for me!”

“Do not. They are all too strong.”

Ken tried to grip Luan, in case he ran in. The Dullahans were armored and Luan only had the painted leather armor and crude mace to fight with. He’d die in a second.

“Yeah, but he can’t take them on alone—”

Calectus whirled as a Dullahan launched an arrow. It buried itself in his shoulder, piercing through the chainmail he wore. The Selphid didn’t stagger or fall, though. Instead, he turned and *leapt* towards the Dullahan who’d loosed the arrow. He swung his halberd and the Dullahan fell as the tip of the halberd sliced through his armor.

Another Dullahan ran at Calectus from behind and two more closed in. Ken saw Luan tense, and tried to grab him. Then he saw Calectus turn and *kick* one of the Dullahans into the air. He landed eight feet away.

Both Humans froze when they saw that. So did the Dullahans, for a moment. The Dullahan that Calectus had kicked had been wearing iron armor, dark and sturdy. He must have weighed at *least* two hundred pounds with it on, and Calectus had kicked him like a ragdoll. Ken’s eyes went to the fallen Dullahan and he saw an imprint in the iron armor.

The other two Dullahans backed away. Too slowly. Calectus whirled his halberd, and Ken heard a ripping sound as it cut through air and one of the Dullahan’s heads. The other one fell back fast and Ken heard her shout.

“Selphid is rampaging! Get back!”

The Dullahans immediately spread out, suddenly acting wary of Calectus. Ken didn’t understand. Rampaging? Was Calectus doing something? Then he saw the Selphid tense and bend his knees. He leapt—and kept going higher.

Calectus jumped *up* as if he were no longer weighed down by his armor or gravity. He leapt six feet into the air and one of his feet crushed a

Dullahan's helmeted head as he landed. He turned—two Dullahans were rushing towards him. Calectus ran one through and grabbed the other's head. His hand was on the other Dullahan's face as the Dullahan stabbed him with a dagger. Calectus *squeezed*—Ken saw his grip close and the Dullahan sagged.

Two left. One turned to run, the other, a female Dullahan with a sword, charged at Calectus. He met her with a roar and cut through armor and flesh with a single strike. He ran after the last Dullahan.

Both were coming towards Ken and Luan. The Humans backed away and the Dullahan saw them, hesitated, and looked over his shoulder. He saw Calectus coming for him and ran at the two young men, holding two hatchets in his hands. He never got to them.

Calectus' halberd cleaved through the Dullahan's steel armor and cut the Dullahan in *half*. Both torso and lower body spun away and Ken felt a splatter of blood hit his chest. He stared down at the stain on his shirt and then at Calectus.

The Lizardman's dead eyes turned towards Luan and Ken. He shifted the grip on his halberd and Ken backed away. Luan raised his voice, shouting.

“Calectus! It's us!”

There was a pause in which Ken thought he could see his life reflected by the tip of the Selphid's halberd, and then Calectus lowered it.

“You two. You're alive.”

It was a statement, not a question. Calectus sagged and suddenly he stopped being a one-Selphid army of destruction. Ken rushed over to him and stared at Calectus' wounds. He had arrows in his shoulder and thigh, numerous bloodless cuts all over his body, and a deformed skull. If he were a living Lizardman, he would have long been dead. As it was, Calectus just looked exhausted.

“Are you hurt, Calectus-san? Do you need—”

Ken had no idea what a Selphid would need. A healing potion? Those didn't work on the dead. Calectus shook his head.

“I have torn this body’s muscles and taken many wounds. I must find another. But later. Where is Geneva?”

“We don’t know. We saw the mage burning the camp and then saw the Dullahans—”

“Assassins. Zalthia was sent by the Centaurs, there’s no question about it. And the Dullahans felt like experienced [Soldiers], not mercenaries for hire. Only one of them ran.”

“You mean...both sides attacked us?”

Ken stared at Calectus. The Selphid nodded shortly.

“There may be more about. Help me find Geneva.”

“And Aiko! She is—Luan, the operating tent!”

Remembering, Ken and Luan both ran for the tent, Calectus following and warily looking around. Ken shouted the moment he saw the tent wasn’t completely engulfed by the flames. He ran towards the smoke, screaming.

“Aiko! *Aiko!*”

The tent was billowing black smoke from the inside. Ken took a breath and rushed towards the opening. He saw fire, felt the heat and saw a dim table—and a body, burning. He ran to it and tried to drag it out.

“*Ken!*”

The flames burned Ken’s hand. He dragged at the body, screaming inside while he tried not to breathe. Someone grabbed him and dragged him out. Ken gasped for air as he cleared the tent. He looked down and saw...

A stranger. A dead Dullahan’s face stared up at him. She wasn’t wearing armor. She was one of the Selphids, only there was no life behind the dead face. Calectus leaned on his halberd.

“Tefiat.”

He shook his head as Ken and Luan looked at him questioningly. The Selphid inside was dead. Only now did Ken feel the pain in his hands and cry out. Luan reached for him.

“We’ve got to get healing potion on your burns.”

Ken shook his head.

“First Aiko. Where is she?”

“Ken?”

A voice from behind. Ken whirled, and then stumbled to his feet and ran. He ran around the tent and then saw Aiko. She was kneeling over another body. Another Dullahan. This one was wearing armor and had a sword.

He was dead. There was blood on Aiko’s hands. She looked at Ken, her hands shaking. She was alive. Ken sagged, and then took in the scene a second time. The Dullahan was dead, and Aiko was not. She had killed him.

The knowledge was in Aiko’s eyes, the proof of it on her crimson hands. She looked at Ken, shaking.

“I—I—”

Ken stared at the dead Dullahan. A scalpel was in his eye and another one was sticking out of his neck. The young Japanese man was no expert, but it looked like an artery had been sliced. His armor was painted with red.

“Aiko!”

Luan ran towards her and hugged her, ignoring the blood. Aiko stared at him, and then at Ken.

“I killed him, Ken. I did not mean to, but I was afraid—”

“You—you did the right thing. He would have killed you.”

Ken replied automatically, but he was still staring at the dead Dullahan. He’d never killed anyone. He’d killed undead, as had everyone else, but Aiko had—had she taken him by surprise? Defended herself and gotten lucky?

Calectus interrupted the moment. He snapped at Aiko as he surveyed the area.

“Have you seen Geneva? Do you know where she was?”

“No, I—”

Aiko seemed paralyzed, but she snapped out of it as she focused on the question.

“I do not know. I think she was at the edge of camp. Maybe?”

“Spread out and search! If you find anyone, run and shout for me!”

The Selphid ordered the Humans. He was more concerned about Geneva than the others, even the other Selphids. Ken looked at Luan and Aiko. She was shaking and he was holding her, trying to comfort her. Luan looked at Ken.

“Go. Find Geneva. Aiko and I will search in a moment.”

Ken didn’t know what to do. He wanted to speak to Aiko too, but Luan was already urging Aiko to move. They all sensed it. Geneva’s camp was the target of the attacks. It was inconceivable that she wouldn’t have been the first one both the assassins and Zalthia went for.

It wasn’t hard to find her. Ken was the first to spot the lone body in front of the blazing inferno that was all that remained of the Dullahan escort. He ran towards the body, shouting for Luan and Aiko. They ran towards him as he skidded to a stop and stared at Geneva.

She was dead.

There was no way she could be otherwise. Her throat was sliced open, exposing red blackness. Her stomach had been pierced multiple times by a blade. Ken stared down at Geneva and felt hot tears coming to his eyes. He turned away as Luan reached her and cried out. Aiko buried her head in her hands, smearing her face with blood.

“Geneva.”

She was gone. But then, to Ken’s horror, the eyes of the corpse opened. Geneva’s still body moved, and a hand rose. It covered her throat and Ken saw her open her mouth.

“Help me.”

Ken screamed and leapt backwards. Luan stumbled back and Aiko shouted in horror. Geneva was dead. There was no way she could be alive. But the voice that rasped from her throat sounded like her. Geneva’s eyes had opened and they were staring right at Ken. How could she be conscious? How—

Had she become undead? Was this some kind of zombie? Geneva stared at Ken. He looked at her, shaking.

“Who—Geneva-san?”

Her eyes flickered. The voice lowered, deepened.

“No. I am Okasha. I am a Selphid sharing Geneva’s body. Her mind is unconscious and she has been wounded badly. I am keeping her body alive. Do you have a healing potion?”

“I—no.”

“Calectus might have one. I’ll get him.”

Luan backed away. Ken heard him running and shouting for the Selphid. Ken just kept staring at the thing possessing Geneva’s body. A Selphid? But he thought that Selphids could only inhabit dead bodies. Could they do it with living ones? And if so...

“Geneva is alive?”

Aiko knelt by Geneva—by Okasha—and stared in horror at the wounds in her stomach. She reached for them, hesitated.

“She is wounded. Badly, I think.”

“Yes.”

Geneva’s hand stayed clamped to her throat. Her eyes moved down to look at Aiko.

“Her heart has stopped. I am manually pumping blood throughout her body. Her body and mind have gone into shock, but I am maintaining a flow of blood to all parts of her body. I have stopped her external bleeding, but I cannot continue this forever. Please. Help her.”

“I—I cannot. I do not have sutures or a needle. You need a healing potion.”

Aiko was helpless. Ken knelt by her and looked into Geneva’s eyes. He addressed Okasha.

“Can you hold on? Will Geneva-san die or—or bleed?”

He stared into her stomach, at the red wounds. There was...something there. Something vaguely orange, blocking the wounds, just inside of the body. The Selphid? Ken shuddered as it slowly undulated. Geneva’s voice replied, cold and distant.

“Geneva Scala cannot die. I will not let her.”

The wording of that made Ken’s blood freeze. Then he heard a shout. Ken turned his head and saw Calectus charging towards them, Luan following.

“Geneva!”

He tore a potion from his belt and splashed it on her wounds. The thing that called itself Okasha pointed out each of the injured sites, telling Calectus to wait while she held together parts of Geneva’s internal organs to be healed in turn. Then the stomach wounds closed and Geneva sat up, her throat mended.

She was alive. Just unconscious, as Okasha reported. But she was alive. Only...what was she?

Ken didn’t know. He realized there was a lot he didn’t know, but then Calectus was telling everyone to run into the forest. Ken did, and suddenly he was staring around, seeing the shapes fighting in the valley, hearing the horn calls. Now that the trials of now were over, he realized the entire valley had descended into hell.

The fighting had begun sometime after Zalthia’s airstrike. Only it wasn’t the controlled battle in the valley. Soldiers charged each other on the hills; mages blasted each other and tore apart the tree cover. The fighting was everywhere.

Everywhere.

In the moments spent crouched, watching mages send arcs of magic raining down into the forests and hearing Calectus report that the Centaurs and Dullahans were fighting all over the valley now, cutting any hope of escape off, he listened to Okasha explain what she was. What Geneva had lost. Why they were...together.

“A Selphid living in a Human body.”

Calectus nodded. He'd come back with another body after going scouting. This time he was a Dullahan, head firmly locked into place. A female Dullahan, in fact. He—or was it she now?—still had her halberd, and the deathblow Calectus had given her body was an open gash, gaping at Ken. He looked away, seeing hints of movement from within. The same thing was in Geneva.

“Why?”

“Her spine is broken. A bone on her neck was crushed when a soldier hit her there. Without me bridging the connection, she would have been unable to move.”

Okasha was sitting, looking at Ken and the others. Aiko and Luan were staring at her, almost unable to look away. Okasha was Geneva and *wasn't* Geneva at the same time. She spoke with Geneva's voice and shared her body, but all of her mannerisms, from the way she sat and the way she spoke, were different. It was terrifying, because it took everything Ken thought he knew about her and turned it upside-down.

The knowledge of Okasha came with the strictest of warnings which Calectus impressed on the three Humans. What Okasha had done was beyond blasphemy. Inhabiting a living body was something the ancient Selphids had done once, when they'd created a terrible empire. They had been overthrown, and ever since, any Selphid found to be inhabiting a living body was put to death.

As was its host.

“It is forbidden by every nation in the world. It would mean Geneva's death and Okasha's if it were found out. You will not tell anyone about this, or I will kill you. Not your friends, not your lovers—no other Selphids either. No one.”

Luan nodded as Calectus stared at him. Aiko and Ken nodded quickly as well. They were stunned by the revelation, but it wasn't the most pressing issue right now. The battle going on between both sides was.

“Whatever the reason, the attack on Geneva's camp seems to have been the start of all-out war. Both companies have abandoned their positions and are attacking with all their forces. It is a bloodbath.”

Calectus had scouted in either direction and found only fighting. There was no chance of running from the battle without meeting the other soldiers. Aiko's voice was shaky as Luan hugged her with one arm.

"I do not understand. Why are they doing this now?"

"At a guess? Because one side got desperate. This is a mistake. Neither company wished to lose the majority of its forces, so they agreed to fight in the valley's center until one side withdrew. Now? They will fight until one side is obliterated. The winner will be mostly destroyed as well, however. As will everyone in the valley."

That included them. Calectus and Okasha were talking about what they could do when Okasha raised a hand.

"Geneva is waking up."

Okasha got up and walked away from the others. Ken watched her back and saw Geneva jerk suddenly. She stumbled—he thought he could see Okasha stopping her from falling. Then Geneva's mouth opened and she spoke to herself. A pause. A short sentence, and then Geneva replied to herself. It was creepy, watching her have a conversation with herself and yet *not* herself. Then Geneva's head turned and she took in the smoldering remains of her camp.

"No."

She collapsed. Her hands shot out, breaking her fall, and Geneva ended up sitting. She stared at the camp in silence. After a while, Ken stood up and made his way over to her.

"Geneva-san? Okasha-san?"

"We're both in here, Ken."

"Oh. Geneva-san...? Geneva?"

"I'm...here, Ken."

Geneva's voice was hoarse from the healing. But it was her. Ken thought it was. The horror in the [Doctor]'s eyes was too real to be anyone but her. Unless it was Okasha pretending to be her sometimes? No. He had to believe it was her.

"Are you alright, Geneva?"

“Alright?”

It was Geneva who looked at Ken, and he flinched away from her gaze. She stared at him, and then at her camp.

“They’re all gone. All the wounded, the soldiers—all of them. Just like that. The goodwill I built up, the lives I tried to save...nothing. It meant nothing.”

He looked at her. There was nothing he could say, so Ken didn’t try. He sat next to Geneva and heard her whispering. Was she talking to Okasha or him? Or neither?

“This was my fault. I thought I could stay neutral, avoid conflict. Instead I became a part of this war. I’ve—failed.”

She stared back at the camp, and then turned her head. Part of the valley had been set ablaze. Struggling soldiers were killing each other in the valley, in the forests. Neither side was falling back. It was to the death this time. The wounded would cry out, and the side that won would deal with them.

“It’s all burning.”

“We must go. It is not safe to hide here, Calectus says. Geneva, I am sorry, but we must run.”

Ken felt wretched saying it to her, but he had seen Centaurs racing through the trees not thirty feet away from where they were hiding. It was only a matter of time before they were found.

Geneva didn’t answer, but Okasha made her stand up. She spoke for Geneva, her voice lower.

“What are our options?”

“Run and fight, or hide and then fight.”

Those were the two conclusions Calectus had come up with. They could head in any direction, preferably away from the valley, but both companies were trying to flank each other and they could head right into a battle group. But if they stayed put, they’d end up meeting soldiers too. And there was no food or shelter here. Either way, it ended with a battle, and Calectus was frank about the odds she’d have against a group of Soldiers.

“I could kill the assassins—but only because I didn’t have to protect anyone. And they weren’t expecting a Selphid. They thought I was alive at first, or they would have aimed for me, not my body. If we run into anything larger than a group of ten, we all die.”

“So that’s it? We choose which way we think is less risky?”

Calectus nodded grimly. She nodded to the camp, checking to make sure her head was on right. Selphids couldn’t take their heads off like Dullahans could. At least, they couldn’t do it and not have the heads begin to rot.

“I had a group of soldiers who could have fought with us, but the airstrike and assassins killed them all. Without another force, there are not enough warriors. Okasha could fight—”

“No.”

Geneva interrupted. She looked at her hand and shook her head.

“I can’t. I can’t let her, either.”

“Just me, then.”

Ken and Luan looked at each other. They wanted to say they could fight, but only Aiko had ever killed someone. But what could they do otherwise? If they had to fight—

Ken had a thought. He stood up and looked up the valley, towards a hill. He tried to squint to see if there was fighting there, but couldn’t see anything through the trees. Luan saw where he was looking and spoke up.

“That’s right! What about Gravetender’s Fist?”

Everyone looked at Luan. He pointed through the forest, up the valley towards where the neutral ground was. Or had been. Calectus frowned and shifted her grip on her halberd.

“You think you can get them to shelter us?”

Ken, Aiko, and Luan traded looks. Luan nodded to Calectus and Geneva.

“We know them. Quallet’s reasonable...I think. There are a lot of our friends in the company. It’s worth a shot, and better than trying to get out

alone, don't you think?"

Calectus considered the idea, and then nodded.

"They're the only other side in this mess. If we find them there, we can try to work together. Otherwise...we'll still be closer to the edges of the fighting."

It was a tenuous plan, but having agreed to it, Calectus didn't waste any time. He had everyone get up and creep towards the neutral zone, stopping when they heard fighting in the distance. Calectus frowned, glancing up at the tall, broad-limbed trees and around warily. There was a problem.

"I can fight small groups, but if we run into a patrol, they will call for help. We need someone to scout."

"I can—"

Luan spoke up, but it was Okasha who volunteered herself and Geneva.

"I'm a [Rogue]. I should do it, with Geneva's permission."

"Absolutely not. You're valuable."

Calectus snapped at her, but Okasha was insistent.

"I can do it, Calectus."

"How? If you're spotted—"

"I have stealth Skills. And I'll do it from above."

Everyone looked up as Okasha pointed at the branches. She looked at Calectus, then flicked her glance towards Ken and the others. Ken thought she was worried about them hearing, but the situation must have warranted it, so Okasha spoke.

"I'll exceed Geneva's limits. I can leap from tree to tree. I did it with my last body. I can do it with hers. Let me do it, Calectus."

"Leap?"

Luan stared up incredulously at the treetops. The branches were thick and could probably hold someone's weight, true, but jumping from one to the next would require inhuman strength! Or maybe the athleticism of a trained Olympian, neither of which Geneva had.

However, that wasn't an issue, as Okasha explained to the Humans.

"We can exceed our limits for a brief period. It is a trick that pushes a body's muscles and nerves past their physical threshold. Other species can do it in times of dire need, but we have no such limitations of the mind. The cost, however, is that the body we inhabit will degrade and break down far, far more quickly."

"Yes, and doing that to a living body would be painful—"

Calectus was frowning and objecting, but Geneva interrupted. She looked from Calectus to the trees, to the other Humans.

"Let's do it. If it means no fighting, I can bear the pain. Okasha, go ahead."

Geneva's head nodded and Okasha spoke.

"I will take over. Geneva, this will tear your muscles."

Geneva's gritted her teeth.

"I can heal them. Do it."

Ken stepped back as Geneva's knees bent and she lowered her posture. There was no sign she was...what had the Dullahans called it? Rampaging? But when Geneva leapt, it was straight up, nearly twice her height. She caught a branch and swung herself onto it, moving with incredible grace. Ken gaped.

"I'll move ahead. Calectus, wait for my signal."

She jumped from one of the branches to the next, a standing long jump that catapulted her to the next branch. Ken turned to Luan to ask the Olympian hopeful if he'd ever seen anything like it, and saw Luan's slack-jawed expression.

"How can she *do* that?"

Aiko asked Calectus, who was scanning the trees from where Okasha had gone. The Selphid answered without turning her head.

"Humans, Dullahans, Lizardfolk...all of your species can do the same. Have you not ever heard of your kind performing great feats in times of need?"

Ken vaguely recalled a story about a mother who had lifted an entire tree off of her son. Or how a passerby would lift an entire car, thousands of pounds, off someone who was trapped beneath. He had no idea what the term for it was.

Was it really possible for everyone to do that? And if so, what could Selphids do with that kind of ability?

Ken looked at Calectus out of the corner of his eye. He—was now a she, and a she from a different species altogether. A Selphid could take over any dead body, and any living body. They could survive wounds that would kill a living person without injury, tap into strength they didn't have...

They were frightening. Not only that, Ken had no idea how they thought or behaved as a species. He had only known Calectus and now, Okasha. Ken was glad they were on the same side, at least, for now.

Something flickered in the trees above him. Ken looked up and saw nothing in the shadows. But Calectus had. She pointed and snapped in a low voice.

“Go. Go!”

Adrenaline and fear shot through Ken's body. He ran, sprinting through the trees, tapping into a speed born of pure fear and proving the Selphids were right. Something moved above him and Ken flinched, but it was Geneva. She ran across a branch as thick as Ken's waist and then leapt to a tree ahead of him.

Ken saw Geneva leaping from tree to tree like a monkey, moving with the same inhuman strength and speed that Calectus had displayed. She called down at Calectus and the others, directing them away from the fighting. Ken ran, lungs and legs burning, watching Luan run ahead of him and hearing Aiko struggling by his side. Calectus took up the rear, watchful, sometimes falling back to clash with pursuers.

When they broke out into the open and ran for the neutral ground Geneva landed and sprinted across the hundred meter gap in less than ten seconds. Ken tried to breathe and run faster as he heard shouts in the distance. However, if they had been spotted, the group of five was deemed less of a threat and no one came after them.

Geneva had paused in the first few trees of the neutral zone. She was sweating, and as Ken ran towards her and practically collapsed, he saw she was gripping her legs.

“Argh.”

Geneva’s face was twisted with pain. Okasha spoke with her voice.

“Try not to move. I am massaging the muscles and removing the...”

“Lactic acid. I can feel everything burning.”

“Torn muscle. I warned you. I am secreting a pain relieving agent, but you must use a healing potion.”

“Later.”

Luan raced into the grove, half-dragging Aiko. She was panting, a ragged note of pain in her voice from the extreme sprint. Calectus was last. An arrow was sticking out of her armor’s shoulder. Ken hadn’t realized they were being shot at.

“Are you alright Geneva, Okasha?”

“Fine. We could use a bit of the healing potion.”

Calectus handed the quarter of a bottle over, cautioning Okasha to be sparing. A few drops and Geneva’s expression of pain eased. She stood up, legs fully recovered from the muscle strain. Calectus shook her head as she studied Geneva.

“The ability to stop bleeding, move a body when critically injured and heal each injury with such precision...this is why it was made forbidden. It is too powerful. Too dangerous. Two souls in one body. Two minds, each with their own set of classes and Skills. An army of such warriors would be unstoppable.”

“Not if the entire world is after you.”

Okasha shook her head and then Geneva took back over. She looked at Ken.

“Are we at the neutral zone?”

“A bit farther, I think. This way!”

Ken took over and the group moved slowly through the forest. He thought they were close to the campground, and then heard a shout. A group of armed soldiers burst out of the trees, shouting. Ken saw Calectus drag Geneva back, leaving Luan, Aiko, and Ken to defend themselves. Luan raised his mace and then Ken heard a shout.

“Hold on! Hold *on*, you bastards! It’s Ken and the others!”

One of the charging soldiers halted and blocked the path of the others. He was holding an axe, and as he came closer, Ken saw it was Daly.

“Bugger me, you lot are alive!”

He strode over to them as the soldiers halted, although none of them sheathed their weapons. Ken nearly wept at the sight of Daly. He was alive! And now that Ken wasn’t terrified out of his mind, he saw more Humans and familiar Lizardfolk, Dullahan, and Centaur faces amid the soldiers.

Daly strode over and gave Ken a one-armed hug that impressed Ken with sweat, blood, and other body odors. Then he clasped hands with a grinning Luan.

“What happened? All we heard this morning was that the [Doctor]’s camp was attacked, and then it was like the world was ending! Both the Centaurs and the Dullahans started fighting everywhere and we’ve been attacked six times in the last hour!”

The young man from Australia led Ken and the others into the neutral ground while the other soldiers went to hide in the trees again. Daly had certainly seen war now, as had the others. He had a huge cut running down his neck and his collarbone. It had cut his armor in half, but it must not have been that deep, since Daly was still upright.

“The Dullahans are claiming that the Centaurs used [Mages] to burn down the camp, and the Centaurs are saying the Dullahans sent soldiers in to burn the camp and blamed it on them. Which side attacked?”

“Both!”

Daly stared at Ken as he and Luan explained what had happened. The Australian shook his head and spat.

“Lies from both sides. Fucking brilliant, am I right? At least Aiko’s safe too. And hey, who’s this?”

Only now did Daly spot Geneva and Calectus. His eyes widened as Ken told him who they were.

“The [Doctor]? I heard about her. The Last Light. You’d better see the Captain. He’ll want to know she’s here.”

Daly took Geneva, Ken, and the others to Quallet’s tent in the middle of the camp. Only this time, Quallet wasn’t the only person inside. When Daly knocked on the flap and ushered everyone in, Ken saw Quallet was standing with the other surviving neutral parties around a map of the valley.

Quallet was there, as was the female Centaur, the leader of Rot’s Bane. Ken thought her name was Exara. What was a surprise was seeing Xalandrass, the war vendor occupying a corner of the tent while he tended to his wounds. Quallet’s eyes widened on seeing Geneva, but when he’d heard what had happened—and heard Calectus was a Level 36 [Honor Guard]—he immediately made room for them around the map.

“Right now we’re holding position and trying not to be a target. But it’s only a matter of time before they send a big force our way to secure this spot, or messengers with an offer to join either side. I’m hoping for a messenger, but I think our chances are slim either way.”

There were symbols all over the map, glowing, indicating where the fighting was. Ken looked down at a shifting landscape of yellow and blue, engulfing every section of the valley and cutting off any hope for an escape route.

Exara, the female Centaur, gave Calectus a brief appraisal of the forces they had with them.

“They killed Ulvial in the first attack. I’ve taken command of the rest of his company with Quallet...we’ve also joined forces with the war vendor’s group. Their camp was also attacked. I’ll say this for the [Merchant], though—he didn’t hide. He crushed at least six of the soldiers who attacked him with his tail. Broke all their bones just like that.”

She nodded at Xalandrass. Ken approached the Naga as the others clustered around the table and discussed options. Technically Geneva was no commander, but the other captains seemed to think she had a place with them and certainly valued Calectus’ input.

Xalandrass had a potion bottle in his hands and was pouring it slowly over the cuts on his body with eyes closed. He opened his eyes warily and then blinked as he saw Ken.

“Ah, little Ken. I did not expect to see you. Alive.”

“Honored Xalandrass.”

The Naga laughed and then grimaced. Xalandrass had a deep cut down part of his serpentine tail, but he was healing that as he spoke with a potion. He’d thrown open his stores and supplied Gravetender’s Fist and the other companies with enchanted weapons and potions. It was one of the reasons why they’d been left alone; they weren’t an easy target. But it was only a matter of time.

He explained this to Ken in a lowered voice as the captains reached the same conclusion with Calectus. Xal’s face was grim as he gave their odds of surviving a flick of the tail.

“If we side with a company, we may have a chance. But what if the company we side with dies, or we are sent into a bloodbath? Or...I suspect we might be stabbed in the back once it is over, regardless. They have violated the terms of war all companies share, by attacking forces on neutral ground. I have had to kill several soldiers myself. It is not...well, it is ironic. And you escaped your attack with her, hm? The [Doctor].”

He grinned at Ken and his tail flicked delicately at Geneva. She was speaking with the others now, grim and horrified, but still determined. She was arguing *against* them trying to cut their way to safety, with only her convictions and no strategy behind her statements. For her, that was enough.

“So that is what she is like. I understand. It is hard to describe her.”

Xal looked thoughtful as he gazed at Geneva. Ken stared at the Naga, and looked hesitantly at the map.

“Honored—”

“Shush. Formalities and flattery are useful when bargaining and flirting, but not now, I think. Say what it is you need to say.”

The Naga flicked his tail up, touching it gently to Ken’s lips. He smiled at Ken. Ken nodded.

“Xalandrass, do you know who attacked Geneva’s camp? There was the Firebringer and Dullahans. Did one side do all of it, or was it both? And why? The soldiers love Geneva. So why...?”

The Naga smiled a touch sadly and shook his head at Ken’s naiveté.

“The soldiers don’t need to know a thing. A single [Strategist] could have ordered the attack, or the leader of either company. And both sides can deny attacking as well. The Centaurs can claim Zalthia was hitting targets of opportunity and failed to recognize Geneva’s camp. The Dullahans sent assassins so they could claim it was a rogue group or mercenaries sent by the other side to frame them. I do suspect it was both, but what does it matter? The deed was done and now we are stuck.”

Back at the table, the argument was getting heated between Geneva and the others. To Ken’s surprise, Luan was joining in the discussion, trying to convince Geneva they needed to fight. But she was insistent and Ken heard her adamant reply as Ken and Xal approached the table.

“There has to be another way. If we fight, we become a target for everyone. I cannot, will not end this all in senseless death.”

“There is no other option. We’ve agreed that staying here is riskier—either we die or they die. I won’t call that senseless!”

Quallet snapped at Geneva, resting his gauntleted hands on the table. She stared back and then flicked her eyes towards the tent. The roar of battle was background noise now, never ceasing.

“There’s a better way. I’ll go ahead of everyone.”

“What?”

The captains stared at her. So did Ken, Luan, and Calectus. Aiko had left, to wash off the blood of the Dullahan she’d killed. Geneva looked at everyone in turn, resolute.

“The soldiers know me. They know who I am. Maybe if they see me, they’ll stop fighting long enough for us to get through.”

“That’s suicide.”

Exara looked troubled, Quallet thoughtful. Calectus was dead against it, and surprisingly, so was Xalandrass. He slithered over to Geneva, smiling at

her. She looked warily at him.

“I hate to disregard such courage, my fair [Doctor], but I must tell you that if you do that, you will die. To no good purpose, either.”

“Why? I understand the risks, but if I can get enough soldiers to see me —”

“Ah, but it is not the soldiers you must worry about.”

Xalandrass cut Geneva off. He flicked his tail, indicating both sides on the map.

“This has gone beyond simple infractions of conduct. Both companies have attacked neutral parties. One company might have broken the rules at first—and I would put money on the Dullahans being the ones—but both sides are party to this now. Any witnesses would bring back terrible retribution onto them. So it is in their best interests that *no one* survives this battle.”

He reached out with his Human-like hands and touched Geneva lightly on the chest.

“You may stop the fighting, but only for a moment. Both sides will want you dead, and will see it happen easily. All it takes is an arrow or spell, from either side. The victor can claim whatever they want, but so long as either group can claim it was an accident, the soldiers will believe it and more importantly, you will be dead. As will we all.”

Geneva stared Xalandrass in the eye, and then nodded.

“I accept that risk. I’m willing to die if you can escape. If I go out, I can at least buy you a few minutes maybe. Enough time for you to get clear of the worst of the fighting...”

“Unacceptable.”

Calectus interrupted. She leaned forwards, glaring at Geneva.

“You are my ward, Geneva. I cannot allow you to throw your life away.”

“What choice do we have, Calectus?”

Quallet cleared his throat.

“If we were to put up a white flag—it wouldn’t stop them from attacking, not now, but what if we negotiated? Swore an oath not to reveal what we saw—”

“We’d never get them to go through all the trouble of finding a [Mage] to administer the spell to every one of us in the company.”

Exara argued back. Ken looked at Luan, and silently, they left the tent while the others argued. Ken didn’t know what they should do, but he had no useful insights. Neither did Luan, so they went into the camp and tried to find their friends.

Daly was resting with the others. He had a bandage on his neck wound—not from Geneva, but courtesy of Aiko. When Ken asked about who was alive, he looked away.

“Etretta’s gone, Ken. She saved my life. Cold bitch walked in front of a lightning bolt for me. I didn’t get a chance to tell her—tell her—”

He lowered his head. Luan and Ken stared at him. Daly wiped at his eyes, swore, and told Ken where to find some of the others.

Ken found Quexa among the wounded. She wasn’t wounded now of course. Xal’s potions were keeping everyone healthy. But she was too injured to continue fighting.

One of her legs had been cut off.

“Hey Ken. I thought you were dead.”

Quexa smiled at Ken when she saw him approach. He stared down at her, at a loss for words. She glanced at the healed-over stump of her leg and then away. She smiled. Tried to smile. It was fake, but she chattered away as if it were nothing.

“Oh. They cut off my leg. Well, I say they—it was a Centaur. With an axe. And my tail. I’m more upset about my leg than my tail, I mean, I could *live* without my tail, but my leg—”

The Lizardgirl’s eyes filled with tears. Ken bent down and hugged her. She sobbed and clung to him.

This was war. Not suppression, hauling dead bodies and fighting the undead. This was war, and they were caught in it. Ken thought they would

die, and Luan thought so too. After Quexa had cried herself to sleep, Luan found Ken, looking worried.

“They’re still arguing over what to do. It looks like we’ll try to fight our way through after all, but Ken...”

He shook his head. Ken stared at him anxiously. Luan had been unwaveringly brave and responsible, but now he looked like he was at a loss for what to do.

“It’s a mess, Ken. We have too many groups here to trust one another when we try to break out. That Xal guy, the Naga—he looks like he’ll make a break for it when the fighting starts. And Calectus is only concerned about Geneva. As for Quallet and Exara, how do we know either one won’t split or try to cut a deal with either side?”

Ken didn’t know. He remembered Quallet when he’d asked if the [Captain] had given up the Americans to the Dullahans. And Exara was a Centaur. Did that mean anything?

Someone strode out of the tent, amid the arguing. Ken stood and saw Geneva headed towards them. The [Doctor]’s face was flushed, and she looked angry and helpless.

“They won’t listen. I’ve told them that if we fight, we’ll only make things worse. We’ll become part of the enemy, not neutral! And we *need* to be neutral. If not—”

She looked at Ken and Luan, and both saw the pain in her eyes. Luan guided Geneva over to the fire. Amazingly, there was food being eaten even with the fighting so close by and occasionally hitting their camp. But people had to keep up their strength. He offered some very dry bread to Geneva as he spoke.

“You’re talking about aid workers, right? Neutral parties?”

Geneva nodded, looking frustrated. Luan nodded too. Ken vaguely understood what they were referring to. There were groups who went into war-torn countries or places where a war was going on. They were on no side and helped victims while trying to remain neutral. It was a good cause and it saved lives. Luan understood, but he did not agree with Geneva.

“*Médecins Sans Frontières*. I know of them too, Geneva. But what they believe in...it’s admirable, but you can’t expect it to apply to things here.”

“I have to believe it. If not, what’s the point of believing in anything? If no one will believe in the rights of victims, in honoring the attempt to aid people—what can be done? Then the only way to resolve anything will be to kill anyone who disagrees with you.”

Geneva’s hand was white on her cup. Luan opened his mouth, and fell silent. Geneva stared past him, towards the battle between the Centaurs and Dullahans.

“Témoignage. That’s a word in French. It means ‘to bear witness’. That’s what Doctors Without Borders believes in. I thought I could be like them, or at the very least, like the Red Cross. So long as I could help—but there’s no one to bear witness to, and even if all I do is help, I’m still a target.”

There was something in her eyes, in her voice. Ken thought he saw hope dying in Geneva’s eyes as she looked at him and Luan.

“What good is neutrality if there is no one to witness it? What’s the use of honor in war—of morality when one side can throw it all away when no one’s watching?”

Neither young man could reply. Geneva got up without a word and left her full cup. She marched back into the tent and Ken heard her raised voice. After she’d gone, Daly came over. He squatted down, pressing at the bandage Aiko had put on his neck and grimacing.

“I heard what she said. That [Doctor]—Geneva, right? She’s the right sort.”

Ken and Luan nodded. Daly paused.

“Trouble is, she’s wrong about this. There’s no reasoning with those bastards out there. Who cares if we bear witness? What good will it do?”

He lifted Geneva’s cup to his mouth and drank it all down. Then Daly tossed the cup aside and grimaced.

“The world is watching. Isn’t that what they say every time shit happens? Back in our world, I mean. The world is watching. Well, I guess

that makes everything alright, don't it? Sure makes *me* feel better, and I'm sure the poor bastards getting shot feel better too, knowing that."

He was right and wrong at the same time. Ken felt that. He thought Geneva was right, but at the same time, he knew Xalandrass and the others were correct as well. He spoke, letting his thoughts out one bubble at a time.

"I think the soldiers do believe in Geneva, Daly-san. Daly. If they saw her, they would stop fighting. However, the leaders of both sides will kill her. And then blame the other side for doing it."

"Yeah, that's the issue. I've heard soldiers speaking of the Last Light. They think she's as close to a goddess as anything—although they don't say it like that since 'the gods are dead'. But what can we do? If we surround her with soldiers, she's a target just waiting for a [Fireball] spell. How can you stop her from being a target and still tell everyone she's here?"

Daly shook his head. Ken stared at the cooking fire, and then at the tent. A target. That was the problem. If only both sides knew what was going on, but how could you tell them? Soldiers believed what their commanders told them—who'd listen to someone from the other side, or someone they didn't know? You had to show everyone the truth, but how could you do that in a war?

At the head of the camp, Ken saw the company banner. The flag of Gravetender's Fist soared above Quallet's tent, shining though there was no sun on it. Why was that?

Oh, right. It had a spell on it to shine in the darkness. So that when everyone was working, people would see the flag and know the company was neutral. That was how it worked.

That was how it was supposed to work. The suppression companies were in the middle of the battlefield, a target for all sides, yet not a target.

A target yet not a target. Ken thought he was on the verge of something. He got up and walked over to the flag, studied it.

"Ken?"

Luan was on his feet. He approached Ken.

"What are you thinking, mate? Something on your mind?"

“Maybe.”

Ken took the flag. It glowed in the half-light of the trees’ shadows, a bright light. Something to identify the Gravetender’s Fist company. To keep them safe. They were safe because they were noticed.

He turned to Luan and Daly, the banner in his hands. Ken lifted it, and saw how both young men stared at it. There. Both of them were looking at the same thing. What if you did that for everyone? Was there a way? He remembered something Xalandrass had said he had in his inventory.

“I think I have an idea, friends. I know how Geneva can go out without being a target.”

“Really? How?”

Daly stared at Ken, and then at the flag.

“Are we going to send a message to one side then? Both?”

“No.”

Ken shook his head as he handed the flag to Daly, and then strode into the tent. He turned to the two of them, smiling.

“We will tell them Geneva is here. We will tell them we are here.”

“Who?”

Luan stared at Ken. Ken grinned.

“Everyone.”

This was the last battle, the final engagement. The Centaurs and Dullahans were locked in combat, battalions maneuvering and charging into combat across the entire valley. A unit of Dullahans charged across the broken ground, trying to cut off a retreating group of Centaur [Mages]. Two wings of Centaur [Lancers] fell on the Dullahans, and both sides were swept up as a group of Lizardfolk rushed to the Dullahan’s aid.

There was chaos on the ground and in the skies. Arrows and spells flew through the air, making the mages capable of flight stay on the ground. Soldiers watched out for banners to identify friends from foes, but were ready for an attack even from allies. It was chaos.

In this situation, who could spend time looking for a third party? Anyone who took a step into the battle zone would be a target. But it was that very issue Kenjiro Murata thought he could solve.

He stood on the edge of the neutral ground, staring down into the valley. The shortest route away from the fighting was through an area where the fighting was thickest. The fact that the most soldiers were here didn't bother him; on the contrary, it was better that he did this here, where there were more to listen.

“Here.”

Xalandrass pressed something into Ken's hand. It was a lovely ring that might have been made of amazonite or a similar stone, inset with beads of clear glass that shimmered with magic. Ken took it and put it on. He didn't sense a difference, but Xalandrass had assured him this ring was the most powerful one in his collection.

That meant the loudest. Ken took a breath, and looked around. Geneva stood next to Quallet, Exara, and Xalandrass. Behind them, the collective forces of Gravetender's Fist, Rot's Bane, the remains of Untimely Demise, Xalandrass' guards, Calectus, Luan, and Aiko, were all waiting. They were all staring at him.

Ken had taken too deep a breath. He released it, took another shaky one, and then felt a hand on his back. Geneva stared into Ken's eyes. Without a word, she nodded.

She trusted him. Ken felt calmer. He took a third breath, and then shouted.

“Ah. Hello? Excuse me!”

The words weren't thunder. They were more like an earthquake, an avalanche, a blasting thousand-man-band's worth of noise that cracked over the loudest explosion and roar of the battle below.

Xalandrass' magical rings to amplify the voice were of the highest quality. Ken's words made every soldier look up at him as a new target. Instantly, Ken saw archers taking aim, commanders, pointing, so he spoke.

“Please! Do not attack! We are not your enemy!”

A brief hesitation. Ken could see confusion on some faces. Who would fall for a lie like that? Who would be so brazen, so stupid?

Ken would. He motioned quickly and Geneva stepped forwards. Every eye focused on her, and Ken heard some cries of recognition.

“This is Geneva Scala, the [Doctor] known as the Last Light! Her camp was attacked—”

A roar went up. Ken spoke over it.

“By *both sides*.”

Silence. Ken looked at Quallet. The man was pale-faced, but he remembered what to do and stepped forwards with Exara and Xalandrass. Ken pointed to all of them in turn. He had the battlefield's attention, for the simple fact that he was loud and the soldiers believed in Geneva.

“This is [Captain] Quallet of Gravetender's Fist and [Captain] Exara of Rot's Bane! They are both suppression companies, and this is

Xalandrass, a [Merchant]! They are all neutral parties in this conflict!”

By the end of that statement, Ken’s own ears were ringing. He could see Xalandrass wincing, as were the people around him. But Ken’s words had had an effect. Soldiers were staring at the captains and Xalandrass, all groups they knew were neutral in any war. Ken’s next words were simple, direct.

“We are leaving. If you attack, we will fight back. But we will not attack you. Please, do not kill us.”

That was all. He took the ring from his finger and put it in his pocket.

Both sides were staring up at Geneva and the others. The frenzy of movement below had become an oasis of inaction. But it couldn’t last. They had to move.

Ken looked at Quallet, Exara, Xalandrass—none of them seemed able to take the first step. Then Geneva moved. She made a sound like a sigh or a prayer and slowly began to descend into the valley.

The others followed. Quallet slowly walked down, axe at his side, looking warily at the soldiers closest to him. Ken followed, unarmed, heart beating out of his chest. Slowly, the rest of Gravatender’s Fist, the other soldiers, weapons sheathed, walked with him.

A sea of bodies were between them and safety. Ken’s heart felt like it would burst as Geneva slowly walked towards a group of Lizardfolk, bloody, spears held uncertainly. She was just staring at them. They stared at her.

They recognized her. How could they not? They might not have ever seen Geneva’s face themselves, but how many soldiers had they met who could describe the woman who’d saved them? And Ken had said it.

She was the [Doctor]. Would they kill her? She was unarmed. They were all neutral parties. And the soldiers stood, knowing that every single one of them had seen this. Would anyone dare attack them? How could they?

Everyone here was a witness.

Slowly, the ranks of soldiers parted. They stood aside, some stumbling back. Others dragged the wounded away. And the wounded did cry out for Geneva. She looked at them, face pale, and slowly shook her head. There was infinite regret in her eyes, but she didn't look away. She stared at the people she could not save.

Ken stared at the commanders. They would be the ones to order the attack. Some were shouting, their voices dim and muted in the silence. Others fought towards Geneva, but were held back. One raised a staff glowing with magic and was dragged from his saddle by his men.

They were a quarter of the way across the battlefield when it happened. Ken heard a group of Centaurs galloping, and suddenly the Dullahan's side was ready to fight. He turned, about to put the ring on and shout, when he saw a group of Centaurs race out of the sea of bodies and slow to a stop. They flanked Geneva on her left, and Ken saw a female Centaur with a bow and a male Centaur he thought he recognized leading them. The female Centaur, a [Captain], shouted.

"Centaurs! You are to refrain from attacking *at all costs*. Any fool who disobeys I will personally shoot!"

Her voice rang out and the Centaurs around her put an arrow to their bows. Their tips gleamed with magic. Evercut arrows.

The words weren't just for the people around her. The [Captain] was staring towards the skies, and Ken saw a shape that had been flying down out of a cloud fly back. Zalthia waved at Geneva from above as she reversed direction. Ken's heart began to beat again. It stopped again when he heard the *thump*. He turned his head and saw a giant Dullahan, a War Walker with a huge sword advancing on Geneva.

The Centaur group backed up and looked ready to loose, but the War Walker began walking on Geneva's right. The voice of the Dullahan head

controlling the massive [Juggernaut]'s body was deep and huge, as if his entire frame was a megaphone for his words.

“I am Bastiom. I will cut apart anyone who attacks the [Doctor] or her company.”

More Dullahans joined him. Now there was a stream of bodies, protecting Geneva as she led the small company across the battlefield. Ken stared. He recognized some of the people in the crowd. He had saved the Dullahan who walked on his right, shield raised towards his own side.

They walked on. Ken found himself walking faster, and then he was listening to Geneva. She spoke quietly with Luan, no longer at the head of the group. There was no need. The message was spreading.

“What can we do? They’ll kill each other when we’re gone.”

Luan was looking at both sides, shaking his head as he spoke to Geneva. Ken heard her low reply.

“We bear witness. That’s all we can do.”

They passed from the valley. Up ahead, the groups of soldiers were lessening. They were going to survive. Part of Ken didn’t believe it. Another part...another part wished the same could be true for the soldiers. He hoped that maybe, after they had left, the silence would continue. Perhaps the soldiers would put down their weapons, talk?

It couldn’t happen. Behind him, Ken could see some commanders moving their forces and soldiers bracing and drinking potions. The fighting would continue. This was only a brief interlude. Peace was a pipe dream.

But it was a dream Ken could believe in. And at that moment, he saw the same hope, the same faith, in Luan and Geneva’s eyes.

Luan stared at Geneva. She seemed lost, looking around, staring at her hands. She looked up at him.

“I don’t know what I’ll do after this. I can’t keep going back to the battlefield, but I don’t know...I don’t know what I should do after this.”

The tall South African man blinked at her for a moment, and then smiled. He looked thoughtfully at Geneva, and then at the sky.

“You know, I heard once that aid workers in conflict zones served for... let’s say a month. But after that, they were forced to take a vacation. In order to stay sane, yeah?”

“What’s your point?”

He put a hand on her shoulder and leaned down to speak to her. Ahead, the forest opened up and a trail appeared. Quallet ordered the company to march faster as both Centaurs and Dullahans broke away, heading back towards the battlefield.

“You’ve been through too many battles, Geneva. Rest for a while. There’s good you can do away from the fighting. And we need you.”

She paused. Geneva closed her eyes, looked at Luan, Ken, and at Aiko and the others. She looked at the Humans from her world and then at her hands. Then she nodded.

“Okay.”

The word was all it took. Behind them, the young Japanese man known as Kenjiro Murata finally began to believe they would live. Ken stared up at the sky, filled with smoke, but incredibly blue.

Behind him, he heard a shout, and then a *thump*. He turned, and saw a plume of smoke rising. War. His spirits sank. Quallet had heard and ordered everyone to *pick up the pace, now!*

They marched on. Ken found himself trailing behind. He couldn’t help but stare up at the sky. He wondered...if there really was a safe place in the world. He couldn’t imagine it, surrounded by death and violence on all sides.

“Ken?”

He looked down. Geneva and Luan had slowed to wait for him. Aiko, helping Quexa move, had turned. Daly was waving at him. Ken realized he was standing still, staring as the group marched ahead.

Luan and Geneva walked back. Luan held out a hand and smiled at Ken.

“Let’s go.”

Ken stared at the hand. He stared at Geneva, and saw something on her face. It was faint, awkward, and full of regrets and sadness. But if you got

past that, it looked almost like a smile.

He hesitated, and then took Luan's hand, leaving the war behind. He went marching away, looking for an answer to his question.

A week later, Ken found it. It wasn't in words, and it didn't come from a person. It was a slow realization that culminated in a moment where he sat on a white beach, staring out into the ocean.

In the days after they'd fled the battle between the Razorshard Armor company and the Roving Arrow company, Quallet had taken charge. His only goal was to get them away from the fighting in case either company sent a force after them. They did not, whether because they were still locked in combat or thought it would be futile, Ken didn't know.

But soon, as the danger became further and further away, the group began to splinter and think of their own needs. Exara was the first to leave with her company, and a good deal of the soldiers in Gravetender's Fist left with their pay—doubled for combat duty—and drifted away at each passing village and town.

But some continued onwards. A good core of Gravetender's Fist, some of Ulviel's forces, and Xalandrass went on with the Humans from the other world. The [Merchant] was sick of combat, and he promised that if they travelled with him as protection, he'd take them to a lovely place where they could rest, safe and away from any danger.

Xalandrass was as good as his word, and the protection of a war vendor meant that the weary company could travel east, taking the main roads until they reached one of the island port-towns. This one was a small haven, not troubled by conflict.

It had a beach. And what a beach it was! Ken had never been to Hawaii, one of the Japanese tourist's must-visit locations, but he'd heard tell of their amazingly scenic beaches. He thought, with no little amount of satisfaction, that Hawaii tourists would have given their left earlobes (and a lot of money) to visit this beach.

It was pristine, untouched by pollution, industrialization, or most other things that had ‘-tion’ in the word. The community of mainly Lizardfolk that lived by the beaches and fished for a living were only too happy to take the gold that Geneva had been bribed with, and feast the Humans and other soldiers when they arrived.

Now, Ken was on the beach, watching people play. He was not in the water. Instead, he was sipping from a very pleasant fruit drink and watching Luan race across the water in a canoe.

The South African man was at home on the water. He’d found that the Lizardfolk used a similar device to a canoe and within the first hour had set about customizing one of their boats to his specifications. Now he was racing the Lizardfolk, most of whom were only too happy to teach an uppity Human a lesson on watercraft.

They had the shock of their lives. So did the other Humans, and Ken, honestly. He’d watched the Olympics, but he’d skipped over the rowing sections, and it was something else to see an athlete row in real life. Luan’s craft skimmed across the water, impossibly fast, and Ken saw a group of Humans and other races on the beach, screaming at him as the Lizardfolk wallowed in the water behind him.

“Go! Go you insane bastard!”

Daly was screaming and chasing after a Lizardman who’d bet gold that Luan could never out-row one of his kind. Quexa was laughing and balancing on the simple prosthetic leg that Geneva had helped design, and Aiko was watching Luan, a flower hidden behind her back.

She was going to confess to Luan today. Ken had mixed feelings about that and let his gaze wander back to Luan. He was circling a small outcropping of rocks and coming back, his paddles smoothly cutting through the water. He really was incredible.

Ken was glad he’d been allowed to see Luan row. He looked up as the race concluded, and saw Geneva approaching. The [Doctor] wasn’t smiling, but neither did she look particularly upset. She just had to work on smiling. It had to be surprised out of her, but it was happening more and more of late. She sat next to Ken, and looked at Luan rowing.

“It’s a lovely place, isn’t it? There’s a girl from Ecuador and she tells me the beaches here are better than her home. Daly and the others say Australia has nothing like it either.”

Ken nodded. He felt at the sand, looked at the water, the greenery. It was a tropical paradise in every sense of the word. It made you almost forget about the violence further inland. Almost.

“There are grander places in Baleros, you know. Xal was telling me about it. There’s so much beauty here. Beaches like this one that can stretch for a hundred miles in every direction, open fields that are filled with grass and edible plants...you can almost understand why everyone’s fighting over all of it.”

Ken nodded again. Geneva stared out across the ocean.

“I made a mistake, Ken. I shouldn’t have tried to work and stay neutral on each battlefield. I was just painting a target on my back. Okasha’s right. Things aren’t the same here.”

“I didn’t mean—”

Okasha tried to speak, but Geneva rode over her.

“There is no Geneva Convention here. There’s only me. I can’t rely on the goodwill of another company, or their morality or honor. I know that now.”

She fell silent. Ken thought to himself and spoke slowly.

“I think...it is good you know that. But Geneva, I think you were right to do what you did. I admired you. So did everyone else. If you had not done what you did, we would have died there.”

“Perhaps.”

The two sat in silence for a long time. They saw Luan trudging towards them as the sun began to fall. He was covered in water, and smiling.

“Hey Ken.”

“Luan.”

Ken stared at Luan, but Aiko wasn’t with him. He opened his mouth, closed it tactfully. Luan saw and smiled. He rubbed at his hair and sat.

“Aiko confessed to me a few minutes ago. I broke her heart. I feel bad about it, Ken, mate, I really do. But I had no choice.”

“Why?”

Did he not like Aiko? Luan smiled ruefully, and looked at his hands.

“Simple. I’m already married.”

Ken stared. Geneva blinked. Luan looked at them and waggled his hands at them. They were dark, but now that Ken looked closely, he could see a band of lighter skin around Luan’s ring finger.

“I don’t wear a ring when I’m in the water. Or travel and paddle. I might lose it or it could get stolen. I normally leave it at home, in a box on my dresser. Funny, I never thought I’d miss an object that much.”

“Do you have a child?”

Geneva looked at Luan. Ken was still grappling with him being married. Luan nodded. His smile faded.

“One year and five months old. I tried not to think about him, or her. Too busy surviving to worry and get distracted, you know? Now...I wonder if I’ll ever see them again.”

The three sat in silence for a while. Below, the people on the beach began to set up a bonfire and food was soon being devoured below. Ken wondered how much gold Geneva had left. Quallet had contributed his share of funds and Xalandrass had left them with some gold as thanks, but they couldn’t do this forever.

The others must have had the same thought. Aiko returned to the group, red-eyed. She didn’t mention what had gone on, and Luan and Ken and Geneva treated her like normal. They talked of mundane things, of hopes for the future.

“You know, Aiko’s been drawing some pictures. Geneva was working with her on it. Aiko made some manga-like drawings depicting hygiene, how to bandage a wound—you know? Practical stuff for everyone. I think we might be able to sell it as a book or something.”

Luan was telling Ken that as they sat around a fire, nibbling at roasted fish on a stick, seasoned with salt and some kind of hot pepper. Ken

nodded.

“Do you know what Captain Quallet is going to do?”

The [Mercenary Captain] had had his fill of leading a suppression company. He’d been drifting around the port, looking grumpy and aimless. Luan grinned.

“I had a thought. We’re all sticking together, us Humans from another world. Why not invite him to lead us as a company?”

“A company?”

The idea surprised Geneva and Aiko, but not Ken. He’d heard Luan speaking with the others about it. Luan nodded.

“We don’t have to fight. We can earn money—but there are advantages to being in a company. It means we pool resources, we support each other. We need that. And who knows? Maybe we can find the others who drifted off on the first day. Maybe some of the Americans made it.”

“Maybe.”

Ken thought about being a company. Geneva had been speaking about teaching some people to do surgery, or at least tell people how to keep themselves clean and manage disease. People needed a [Doctor] outside of war, even with healing potions. If she could do that, what could everyone else do?

Daly leaned forwards and flicked a bit of bone into the fire. He’d joined them for dinner, although he was usually fussing about Quexa. He’d been looking out for her ever since they’d left the battlefield, and it had been he who’d carved the prosthesis she was using.

That was another thing. Geneva’s knowledge of medical prosthesis was heads and shoulders above the crude stumps and peg legs that people here used. Everything from penicillin to blood transfusions would revolutionize this world, and all she needed was time, coin, and the people with the right skills or Skills to help her. That was what she could do. Ken wasn’t sure what he could do.

He was a Level 18 [Negotiator] now. His leveling had been meteoric that first night he’d slept and it seemed like this was what he wanted to do.

Luan was convinced his rowing abilities could be put to use as a [Scout], or a Runner delivering messages. And Daly?

He was a [Warrior]. Not just a [Warrior], but an [Axe Fighter]. He still believed what he'd told Ken. There were times to run and times to fight. Whatever the others did, he and some of the other Humans who'd been in Gravetender's Fist would be there to protect them. Now he leaned back, chewing and spoke thoughtfully.

"You know, the Red Cross company isn't a bad name. But it doesn't have the right ring to it, especially if we're going to be fighting. That's why I was thinking Geneva could have her company, and we'll make our own."

The others looked at him. Ken's heart sank.

"But if you are in another company Daly, won't we separate?"

"Yeah. There's that. But we're not Red Cross. We might fight, or take guard jobs. I don't think Geneva's willing to call us Red Cross, and I wouldn't like that either."

Geneva nodded quietly. Besides Okasha, several other Selphids had appeared one day, and Calectus was still sticking around. They wanted something from her, and Ken sometimes worried what it was.

"But we shouldn't form different companies. Or if we do—we should all be part of one larger company. We're on the same side. Ken showed us that. We have to work together. All of us."

Luan was speaking, and Daly was nodding and spreading his hands wide, not disagreeing, but not having an answer he could give. To Ken's surprise, Geneva smiled, and because that was rare and special, everyone looked at her.

"You know, I think we have something like that. Back in our world."

It took Luan a moment to catch on to what she was saying, Aiko five seconds, Daly six, and Ken had to have Aiko whisper the answer to him before his face lit up. The others instantly agreed that it was a good idea. They were talking about having Quallet join to help them out as a paid leader when Daly frowned, looking worried.

"What about Lizardfolk? Dullahans? Centaurs? Selphids? And other races, are we going to let them all in?"

“Why not?”

Luan laughed and nudged Daly. The Australian man looked covertly at Quexa and she waved at him and told everyone that he kept staring at her. He laughed and that was that.

Everyone was better than no one. Ken realized their new company would have all kinds of people in it. People like Aiko, who had talents that could be used outside of fighting, people like Geneva, who were useful wherever they went. There would be fighters like Daly who could do what was needed, and peerless people like Luan who had one skill they could do better than anyone else.

And then there was Ken. He’d help them all get along. That was his calling, and that was what made him happy. He liked understanding people, and he believed in people. That wasn’t always easy.

It was now. Ken found a cup and raised it. He’d explained how to toast in Japanese, and now the others raised their cups, shells, or in Daly’s case, tankard, with him. They didn’t shout ‘乾杯’, though. Instead, they looked at each other and smiled.

“Together?”

Luan looked at Ken. Ken grinned and looked at Aiko. She blinked, glanced at Daly, and then looked at Geneva. Two souls looked out from her eyes, and Geneva smiled again.

“Together.”

A little while later, an angry Fraerling paced back and forth on his desk, reading the reports that were written on pages as tall as he was. Niers Astoragon was not in a good mood, and the reason for that was the chessboard behind him.

It was ghostly, the pieces magical. They had been set up in the middle of a game and they had stayed in that same place for...what? Months? Years?

Probably just a month. But that was too much. Niers glanced at a letter with gold-rimmed edges. He studied a map of Izril. He kicked over a tiny cup of wine and grudgingly read the latest report before the wine made the ink illegible.

It was a general report of the newest companies, the recent events in one corner of Baleros. A [Strategist] had to know how the winds were blowing as well as rumor and gossip in order to do his job. Well, some strategists could just wing it and did better ignorant than they did well-informed, but Niers preferred knowledge to idiocy.

He sighed as he studied the outcome of the battle between the Razorshard Armor company and the Roving Arrow company.

“Fools, all of them.”

There was no return for either company. Their reputations were ruined, and they had destroyed themselves fighting over a valley that was practically unusable now. Neither side would back down and so everyone lost. Typical of Centaurs and Dullahans, really.

Something caught his eye as Niers absently paged through the report. This was about a new company that had declared itself. That wasn't in itself noteworthy; new companies could come and go at the drop of a hat. Three drunken idiots could call themselves a company, so his [Spies] and [Informants] had to sift carefully through all the rumors and declarations to pick out companies that might actually be noteworthy.

There was little special to recommend this one, which was why it was just a few lines in the report. It had a few sub-companies, listed with less than a hundred members in each. That was also normal, but it was the *name* of the entire overall company that caught Niers' eye because it was so audacious.

What a name. Who would come up with it, in Baleros of all places? But there it sat, glaring up at Niers. A declaration to the world. A statement of intent, or what the company represented? He had no idea. Niers stared down at the name written in ink.

The United Nations.

That was it. No appellation marking them as a company. No declared ties marking them as a part of a larger company or affiliated with another group. They had a strong connection with a local Naga war vendor...and several of their members were former undead suppression company members. One of them, Quallet Marshhand, was an individual of some skill.

But nothing more.

United. It was a word Niers had dreamed of, had spoken to the other Great Companies of Baleros about. It was a hope for this continent, for a world, that Magnolia had tempted him with. But it was an empty dream.

Yet someone had the same one. Niers glanced at the name and memorized it, just in case. Then he flipped the page and kept reading. He had a job to do. Every now and then, Niers would glance at the chessboard's pieces that had not moved and look away.

There was something curious about Niers after the report. He was still in a bad mood, but as he filed the report away he had a curious sensation. It was a subtle feeling, but he had trained himself not to ignore his instincts. Something cried out to him as he opened the report and stared down at the name in ink.

Yes, he could feel it. It wasn't coincidence. It wasn't chance. This was only the start. And everything he had witnessed, all the little pieces, they were falling into place. Something was happening.

The world was beginning to move again. Behind Niers, on the chessboard, a piece slowly slid forwards and stopped.

4.18

In the hour after she woke up, Erin learned much of screaming. More specifically, of being screamed at. It wasn't a pleasant experience at the best of times, even if you liked the person who was screaming at you.

And Erin did not like Miss Agnes. Not anymore. For that matter, she didn't much like Maran or Safry, and she deeply regretted hiring them. Unfortunately, regrets meant little at this point.

“—*thieving monster!* You stole my best workers, my business—I shouldn't be surprised if I found you stole money from me as well! When I, out of the goodness of my heart, let you work in my inn, I never expected —”

“Shut up, Miss Agnes.”

“*How dare you!*”

The angry [Innkeeper] and owner of the Frenzied Hare shrieked as Erin glared at her. She was spitting as she yelled, and Erin had had enough. It had been two minutes since she had stormed into Erin's inn and begun yelling—her and two other older Humans, one a man in his late forties, the other a woman who was as old as Miss Agnes, but had aged far better.

Erin glanced at them as Agnes drew breath for another tirade. She waved away Lyonette and Ishkr who were hovering about and walked out of spit-range as Miss Agnes began to shout.

“Don't you dare turn away from me, you—you brazen hussy! You ingrate! I should be calling the Watch on you! I said to come back! Do you hear me!? Do you—”

She really needed better insults. Erin had heard Ryoka say a lot worse than 'brazen hussy' when she stubbed her toe. She walked into the kitchen as Miss Agnes shouted. The older [Innkeeper] stormed after Erin—

And backed away fast as Erin walked out of the kitchen with a knife and a frying pan. The other man and woman stood up as Erin calmly stared at Miss Agnes, who'd gone white. In the refreshing silence, someone coughed.

“Need a hand, Erin?”

“No, I’m fine, Ceria. Sorry about the noise everyone. Ishkr, Lyonette, just keep serving food. I’ll handle this.”

She waved at the Horns of Hammerad and addressed the room. The Gold-rank adventurers who’d been trying to enjoy their breakfast in peace, as well as Erin’s staff got back to work. Most of them kept staring, though. Pisces was already taking bets from Jelaqua and Typhenous on whether it would come to a fight.

“It’s never boring here. Never. I could eat and watch this all day if I wasn’t worried my body’s stomach would explode.”

Erin ignored the Selphid’s comment as she slowly pursued Miss Agnes back to the table. The man who’d come in with her, a guy with a bushy red beard and his fair share of wrinkles, coughed delicately.

“Miss Agnes, I believe you’ve upset, ah, Miss Solstice is it? Why don’t we start again. Miss Solstice, please, there’s no need for violence.”

“There’s no need for shouting, either. How about a deal? You shout and I’ll poke. Now, what’s this about?”

Erin deliberately put the knife and pan on the table as she sat back down. The other two stared at her as Agnes edged her chair back towards them. The woman’s face was dead white. All bark and no bite, Erin guessed.

It was the other woman who coughed delicately.

“Miss Solstice—”

“My first name is Erin.”

“Miss Erin, then. I fear we’ve gotten off to a bad start.”

The woman gave her a charming smile. She had a few streaks of grey running through her long brown hair, but she was still in good shape. She had a very nice smile, and a friendly air that made Erin want to relax around her. However, because that put Erin in mind of Lady Magnolia’s sweet words, the effect of the Skill was severely diluted. Erin crossed her arms.

“Who are you and what do you want?”

The smile faltered. The woman exchanged a glance with the man. He stood up and offered Erin a callused hand.

“Timbor Parithad, at your service, Miss Erin. My apologies for Agnes. I am the owner of the Drunken Swordsman, one of the finest inns in Celum.”

The Drunken Swordsman? Erin vaguely recalled hearing about the inn, but she’d never been inside. Erin shook Timbor’s hand. The woman sitting next to him smiled again, without the Skill.

“Ulia Ovena. I’m an [Innkeeper] as well. I run Blazehound, an inn just off of the main street. We cater to adventurers—we’re more like a bar than an inn, to be honest.”

“Hi. I’m Erin. What are you doing in my inn?”

The [Innkeepers] exchanged a glance. Timbor coughed, and looked at Agnes, but the woman stared at him as if, after shouting and threatening Erin, her role was at an end. He turned and smiled at Erin.

“Miss Erin, I’m afraid we’re here about the unpleasant business revolving around Miss Agnes’ inn and yours. We heard that another [Innkeeper] had been helping to manage the Frenzied Hare of course, and then there was that commotion around the magic door the Horns of Hammerad brought to the city...well, we knew there was an inn here, but we hadn’t introduced ourselves properly before, well, as we understand it, there were a few disputes between Miss Agnes’ inn and yours. We’re here to discuss the matter, as it were.”

“Yeah?”

Erin raised her eyebrows. The longwinded speech had done little to make her feel happier about the other [Innkeepers] being here. She hadn’t had breakfast yet. Timbor’s smile wavered. Ulia took over without missing a beat. She had a pleasant voice, too. Charming voice, nice looks, great smile...was all that from her Skills?

“Miss Agnes has told us a few things, Miss Erin. She believes you brought some business to her inn and then took it away. These ah, [Actors] that have put on those marvelous plays in Celum—”

“Fascinating stuff. Had to see one myself. *Hamlet*. What a stunning performance. I had no idea that Watch Captain could perform like that.”

Timbor coughed as Ulia glared at him. The female innkeeper continued.

“Yes, well, Miss Agnes seems to think that you stole her business, since the group mostly eats at your inn and they perform elsewhere now. And then of course, there’s the matter of Safry and Maran. You ah, stole them from Miss Agnes—”

“I hired them. They wanted to work in my inn.”

“Yes...but then you fired them. Not three days after they’d begun working. We’ve spoken with both young women and they’re quite upset.”

Erin shrugged. Her face was stony.

“They were terrible workers.”

“How *dare* you.”

Miss Agnes glared at Erin, rage overcoming fear for a moment. She pointed a trembling finger at Erin.

“They were my best workers! My only workers! And you took them and then *threw them away*! For a Gnoll and a Drake? How dare you? *How dare—*”

Timbor dragged Miss Agnes down into her seat as she tried to stand up. He smiled weakly at Erin.

“We’re here on their behalf, Miss Erin. We, that is to say, the innkeepers of Celum, feel there’s been a bit of a miscarriage of justice, and we’d like to sort all this out without getting the law involved.”

So that’s what it was. Erin stared from face to face.

“The innkeepers? You mean, you’re representing all the innkeepers in Celum? What, are you some sort of Guild? The Innkeeper’s Guild?”

Ulia smiled as Timbor snorted.

“Not a Guild, Miss Erin. An association.”

Erin stared. She could do a blank stare incredibly well, and, what most people didn’t know, she could do it even when she knew what was going on. Sometimes she did it just to annoy Ryoka or Pisces. In this case, Erin knew what Ulia meant, but she bought time as the woman explained it to her in order to think.

An association was different from a Guild. Formal Guilds like the Runner's Guild, Merchant's Guild, Adventurer's Guild, and so on had wide-ranging networks that spread across continents. There was an Adventurer's Guild in most cities, and if the ones in Izril were distinct from how Terandrian Guilds did their business, they were all based around the same idea.

However, associations were just that. No one was going to join the Innkeeper's Guild because that sounded stupid and [Innkeepers] and [Barmaids] had better things to do. A Guild was a lot of work to maintain and there was no point to having one. But in a city, all the [Innkeepers] would still know of each other and support each other if they had a good relationship. It was like how Krshia had a network of [Shopkeepers] and [Merchants] in Liscor she could direct business to and get help from.

An association could be a very powerful thing. Or a pain in the ass. The not-quite-smiling [Innkeepers] sitting in front of her were clearly hinting that they could be one or the other, and yet they still failed to intimidate Erin.

A few weeks ago, Erin had dealt with annoying Frost Faeries who could bury her inn in ice if she irked them. As far as she was concerned, the association of Celum's [Innkeepers] weren't half as annoying as a single faerie.

"So that's where the matter rests, Miss Erin. If the [Barmaids] weren't to your satisfaction, well, it's still unfair to Miss Agnes to take her help, and to them. They're jobless now, and of course they can't go back to the Frenzied Hare. But I've had a chat with some of the others and Timbor's agreed to put them in his inn and trade Miss Agnes a few of his workers. So that's settled. However, this issue of taking workers and business..."

They were threatening her. Before she'd had her poached eggs and cheese sauce on toasted bread. Erin had worked hard on that breakfast—yesterday. Lyonette had warmed it up and it was lovely and hot. It was getting cold. Erin's eyes narrowed.

"I gave Miss Agnes that business. I helped the [Actors]. They're not her clients. Her inn's too small to do a proper play in, anyways. And Maran and Safry were lazy, cowardly, and huge jerks. *They* wanted to join my inn, and that was because I was willing to pay more than Miss Agnes."

“You can’t just—”

Agnes shut up as Ulia gave her a warning glance. Ulia smiled apologetically at Erin and spread her hands on the table.

“Miss Erin—may I call you Erin?”

“No.”

“Ah. Miss Erin, then. We’ve been [Innkeepers] for many years. As many years as you’ve been alive, I’ll wager. And while we in Celum understand competition is healthy, there’s a lot to be said for working together. If everyone was fighting over patrons and stealing each other’s best workers, well, things could get nasty. That’s why our, ah, association works together. What would you call a system where everyone was at each other’s throats, fighting for customers? Anarchy?”

“How about a free market?”

Ryoka was passing by the table. She waved at Erin and pointed to the poached egg on her plate.

“Good stuff. I’m going out with Ivolethe. You got things here? Want me to get Klbkch?”

“No, I’m fine.”

Erin’s stomach growled loudly as the [Innkeepers] stared at Ryoka. Their eyes found the floating Frost Faerie as she carried another wobbly poached egg through the air. Erin had no idea what that must have looked like. She took a breath and the three innkeepers looked back at her.

“I’m not paying Miss Agnes anything for anything. And I’m not saying sorry. And I’m not paying Maran and Safry either.”

“Miss Erin—let’s be reasonable here. A dispute with the innkeepers of Celum is not—what would happen if we started fighting? Would you like us to take *your* guests? What about your workers?”

Ulia was trying to negotiate. She’d hinted quite unsubtly that a few gold pieces could smooth everything over. Erin wasn’t having it. She had an upset feeling in her stomach now, and not just from the lack of food.

“No.”

“Your guests—”

Erin turned in her seat. The Gold-rank adventurers were filing out of the inn, but she had a few Drakes and Gnolls who’d braved the chill to be here in the morning. Some guests from Celum, too. Erin waved at them.

“Go ahead. Steal my clientele. If you’ve all got magic doors leading to Liscor, go on and have them go through. But Drakes and Gnolls don’t like most Human places. They only go into Celum to look for better prices. I don’t think they want to stay at a Human inn. And try hiring my workers, too. Drassi and Ishkr. I’m sure they’d love walking a hundred miles to Celum every day rather than work at my inn.”

She glared at the [Innkeepers]. They glared back, all pretenses of joviality forgotten. Timbor coughed deeply and growled.

“Listen here, you brat. We’re experienced innkeepers who know a lot more about this business than some upstart. I suggest you make things right now, rather than see what happens if you decide to make this a real issue. I’m a Level 24 [Innkeeper], Ulia’s a Level 27 [Innkeeper] and—”

“*I’m* a Level 30 [Magical Innkeeper].”

Timbor choked on his words. Erin stared at him, and at Ulia’s suddenly pale face. She stood up and grabbed the knife.

“You want to threaten me? In my *own inn*?”

For a second Erin thought about using her [Inn’s Aura] skill to scare them, but then she spotted someone walking in the front door. She waved him over and then pointed to Pisces as he went back for a sixth egg.

“That’s Pisces. He’s a [Necromancer] and one of my guests. He lives in my basement. You want to cause trouble? He’ll pull all the bones out of your body *through your nose*. You want to hire someone to make trouble? Come meet my security. Bird?”

The Humans turned and Ulia screamed. Agnes and Timbor turned pale as Bird, holding a freshly-shot bird stared down at him. The Antinium lifted a hand slowly.

“Hello. I am Bird. I shoot birds.”

Agnes, Ulia, and Timbor all stared in horror at Bird, Pisces, and then at Erin. Erin folded her arms and nearly cut herself with the knife.

“Get out.”

They went. Erin sighed as the door leading to Celum slammed shut and waved at Lyonette.

“Eggs! Food! Some for Bird, too!”

Lyonette rushed over, looking apologetic.

“I’m so sorry, Erin. Pisces just took the last of them...”

She pointed to the necromancer, who took one look at Erin’s expression and decided to finish his meal outside at speed. Erin flipped over the table she was sitting at.

“*Aargh!*”

She spun as the door to Celum opened and threw the knife she was holding. The blade *thunked* into the wall as Octavia froze in the act of opening it. Erin blinked. She’d thought it was Agnes, coming for one last word. Octavia took one look at the knife lodged in the wall of Erin’s inn, and then closed the door without another word.

After a while, Erin had some cheese sauce on bread while Bird ate the bird he’d shot. Raw. That was how she started her Monday morning.

She assumed it was a Monday. It would have felt so wrong if it were a Thursday.

Some days Lyonette felt very bad for Erin. It was easier to feel bad, now. In the days since Erin had fired Safry and Maran she’d become a lot more accommodating to hearing suggestions from Lyonette, and had accordingly started treating her like a partner in running the inn, rather than, well, another Toren.

Erin’s job wasn’t easy. Lyonette knew that. Only Erin could make the wonderful meals that kept her guests coming back, and even if she did store

the food for days in advance, she still had to cook for a few hours each day to keep ahead of her customers' large appetites. Especially Moore's.

Added to that, Erin had to deal with all the big issues, like Miss Agnes and the other [Innkeepers] coming down and trying to extort money or an apology from her. Lyonette had hovered about while the entire tense discussion had taken place, feeling guilty about the whole thing. But Erin had told her it wasn't her fault and Lyonette had quite liked the part where she kicked them out of her inn.

"Still, it might be trouble down the road so watch yourself if you go into Celum. Uh, I don't know if they'll do anything. They might just spread nasty rumors, but you don't know."

Lyonette nodded as Erin warned her afterwards, glumly eating her cheesy toast. She left Lyonette to clean up while she tried to persuade Bird to let her cook the goshawk he'd shot—or at least pluck it first.

There weren't many dishes left to take to the kitchen. Ishkr was extremely good at clearing tables, and he was already happily washing the prodigious stack of plates, bowls, silverware, and cups. Lyonette left him to the idle work since the Gnoll liked it so much and decided to play with Mrsha in the meantime.

Erin had decided that the task of raising Mrsha was just as, if not more important than keeping the inn running. Thus, Lyonette had free reign to do what was needed to keep the Gnoll cub occupied. Sometimes that meant running about after her, playing catch, or just finding her.

She hadn't left the inn. Lyonette was watchful of that, but Mrsha wasn't in the common room either. She could be upstairs or in the basement, bugging Ceria or Pisces as they studied their respective spell books.

Lyonette guessed upstairs. Mrsha had been worn out from yesterday's trip to Garia's home with Ryoka and she might be taking a nap now. Ryoka hadn't said much about the experience, but for some reason Mrsha had been leaping around and trying to do handstands the entire time she'd been back.

Maybe she could ask Ryoka about it? Was that being nosy? Lyonette still didn't know how to talk to the surly Runner girl. Ryoka wasn't in the inn to ask, anyways. She had gone off to practice 'jumping around like an idiot and staring at the wind', which Lyonette took to mean...exactly that.

Now Lyonette ascended the wood staircase, calling out for Mrsha.

“Mrsha? Are you there?”

She heard a faint sound, a *clacking* noise, that of something connecting with a wooden surface. It was coming from her room. Frowning, Lyonette pushed the door to the room she shared with Ryoka and Mrsha and saw the Gnoll.

“What are you doing there?”

The small Gnoll cub spun guiltily as Lyonette entered the room. Lyonette saw a chessboard sitting in the center of the room, and then blinked as she saw ghostly chess pieces arranging themselves on the board. Mrsha turned as a line of pawns flew into place. She grinned happily and, to Lyonette’s horror, scattered them across the room with a swipe of the paw.

“Mrsha! Stop that!”

The white-furred Gnoll blinked innocently up at Lyonette, and then turned eagerly to the board. Lyonette saw the fallen pawns soaring back across the room and falling back into place on the board. It was an eerie sight, but she knew that across the world, somewhere, someone else had picked up the pieces. Mrsha watched a pawn settle into place and poked it.

Instantly, the pawn scooted back. The Gnoll poked it away, and grinned happily as the pawn slid back, with more force this time. She pushed at it again—this time the pawn stayed stubbornly in place. Mrsha *heaved* and the pawn—and board—went flying.

The Gnoll was randomly shifting pieces around the board or knocking them to the floor and watching them as they soared back up and returned to their original position. She had no idea that this was because someone else had to pick them up, and probably thought it was magic, or some amazing game designed just for her.

However, Lyonette understood the issue and rushed to stop Mrsha from upsetting the board—and the board’s mysterious owner—any further. By the force which the pieces were being slammed back on the chessboard, Lyonette guessed the other side was getting increasingly angry.

She winced as the last chess pieces were slammed into place. Mrsha squirmed, trying to get to the board to overturn it once more. Lyonette

grabbed her, put the upset Gnoll in time-out, and picked up the chess board. She rushed downstairs to tell Erin about it. On the way, Mrsha tripped her. The Gnoll thought it was incredibly amusing to watch the pieces and board right themselves.

Lyonette did not. Mrsha got a spanking, and then she took the board—carefully—down to Erin.

“Oh no. Oh my god. I—I *forgot*.”

Erin stared in horror at the chess board that Lyonette had brought down from her room. A howling Mrsha ran about the inn as Lyonette chased after her. Erin ignored Mrsha as she tried to appeal to her for sympathy. All of her attention was on the ghostly pieces arranged on the board in front of her.

The pieces were frozen in the middle of a game. Just as they had been when she’d left them. Erin stared at a knight which was threatening her king. She...vaguely remembered that move, the last one her mysterious opponent had made. It had been on the day she’d left with Toren on the sledge. She’d been dreaming of what to do to counter it—probably move her king rather than lose her bishop—when she’d been abducted to Celum.

Now, far later, the board was rearranged exactly as Erin had left it, despite it having been messed up countless times by Mrsha. Her unknown opponent had remembered and restored it each time. They had been waiting. For her.

“How could I?”

There was no way to explain the pain in Erin’s chest. She was a chess player, a maniac who loved the game. She knew her opponent was as well. She—or he—had been waiting for Erin to make the next move. All this time.

It was like leaving someone hanging when you were playing a game of online chess, only a thousand times worse. Erin respected her opponent on the other side of the board. But she’d forgotten about them.

They hadn't forgotten about her, though. Once Lyonette had finally caught Mrsha and made the Gnoll take a nap, she explained to Erin about finding the board and playing a few games with the mysterious owner herself.

"It was...six games, I think. I did it every now and then, when I didn't have anything to do. I leveled up, but whoever was on the other side got bored of playing with me, I think. After the last game they reset the board to this. I tried playing—so did Olesm. But once the other player realized we weren't you, they reset the board to this. Every time."

"I don't believe it. They were waiting."

Erin's hand trembled as she stared at a piece. She pushed it to one side and it snapped back into place. Lyonette winced, as did Erin. The feeling of the invisible opponent was made clear by the motions of the chess pieces. They were beyond irate. Incensed was probably a better word for their feelings at the moment.

"I put it in my room so no one would take the board or mess with it. I'm so sorry I forgot to tell you!"

"No, I understand. I should have remembered. It's just—I forgot. I can't believe I forgot. I have so much to do and I—"

Erin stared at the board. She looked at the pieces and whispered.

"I'm sorry."

"Would you—would you like to play?"

Lyonette timidly floated the suggestion, but Erin didn't know. She felt—guilty. As guilty as she'd ever been of anything. She wanted to apologize, to beg for forgiveness for abandoning the game she loved. But there was no way to do that.

There was only the game. Erin stared at the board. So long. She'd played Go with the others, but this was different. This was chess. The thing she lived and breathed. So what if a computer could beat the world's best players? So what if there were video games?

This was eternal. Erin's hand wavered as she took the king piece. She lifted the ethereal chess piece up and slowly placed it in front of the knight. And waited.

Silence. Erin knew her opponent had seen the move. It was a legal one. One of the only legal moves Erin could make, in fact. But did they think it was her?

A minute passed. Then two. Erin grabbed Mrsha as the Gnoll snuck towards the table. The Gnoll blinked up at her.

“Touch the board and you will regret it.”

Erin smiled pleasantly at the Gnoll, without a trace of the anger she’d directed towards Agnes and the others. She loved Mrsha, and Mrsha knew that. The Gnoll cub looked into Erin’s smiling face, turned, and ran yelping up into her room.

The knight on the board moved. Erin’s head snapped back around and she saw the knight slowly shift positions. It moved up, down, and stole one of her pawns.

A good, safe move. But it felt grudging. The other player didn’t think it was her. Erin half-smiled.

“Gotcha.”

She pushed up a bishop and simultaneously threatened a rook and the other player’s queen. Thanks to the knight’s absence it had been possible. That was a trap that Erin had set, oh, about a month ago.

It floored the other player. They probably had seen it coming, but they’d been too upset over Mrsha. Understandably so, but there was no mercy in chess.

This time, the next move came within a minute. Erin saw the queen move to threaten one of her pieces. She still took the rook. Double attacks were there to punish. Then she hunted down the knight, stole the queen, and ended the game in six minutes.

She hadn’t forgotten. Erin cracked her fingers and winced at the pain. The other player hadn’t moved the pieces since Erin had checkmated the king. She thought they might be in shock.

So Erin reached out, turned the board around so she had the black side and reset it. She left the white side as it was. A challenge.

The board reset itself. Pieces flew into place. Then a knight leapt over the pawns' heads. Erin smiled and pushed forwards a pawn.

"Erin?"

She turned. Pawn the Antinium was staring at her. He was hovering right over her shoulder. She nearly fell out of her chair.

"Pawn? What are you doing here?"

"I have been here for the last five minutes. As have my Soldiers."

She turned and saw a group of painted Antinium lined up patiently while Lyonette served them fried fish and honeyed milk. Erin hadn't heard them come in. She blinked at Pawn and then saw a piece on the board move. She quickly turned back to it.

"Sorry Pawn! I'm uh, playing a game. How are you?"

"I am well. My Soldiers and I are taking a break from combat duty in the Hive. We have slain many monsters and I am showing the new ones around."

"Really? Cool! Uh...combat duty?"

Erin was distracted. She was pondering her move. Pawn nodded.

"I see you are occupied. You are playing an interesting game already, I note. Belgrade and Anand would both love to see this. As would Olesm, I suspect."

"Isn't it good? This is the Tennison Gambit right here. See how they're gambling their pawn? It comes from the Réti Opening—you know, starting with the knight. Belgrade and Olesm can't really get their heads around hypermodern strategy yet, although Anand is good at using the wings to dominate, which is why he usually beats Belgrade. I wonder what would happen if I used a reverse Budapest Gambit here? Nah...is that stupid? Hm..."

"I believe this game may take a while. Or the subsequent games will. Lyonette, would you mind if I left my Soldiers here to visit the city?"

Pawn left. Erin was vaguely aware of that, and of a Soldier with yellow splatters of paint on his body sitting and staring at her. At some point Olesm rushed into the inn, screaming.

“I’ve got to write this down for my newsletter! Quick! Anand, let’s set up a board here! And Belgrade—oh. Sorry. Are your wounds fine?”

Erin looked over.

“Hey! You two are hurt! How did that happen?”

Anand and Belgrade paused. Both were covered in some kind of orangeish slime that was covering several cuts. Belgrade clicked his mandible together.

“We were wounded in defense of the Hive. Our worst injuries were healed, however.”

“Lyonette! Get a potion! And Anand, pull a chair up if you want to see. Look at this.”

Erin waved the chess players over and they crowded around. She kept playing as she explained her position.

She lost that game. It was a brutal match where her opponent tried to strip all her pieces away and Erin did the same. It ended fast, and when it was over, Erin slowly rearranged her board.

There was a silence in her mind. A quietus, that overwhelmed the sounds of Olesm chattering and the Soldiers covertly feeding Mrsha scraps of fish when Lyonette wasn’t looking. The last two games had been...a test, Erin felt. She’d caught the other player off-guard and won the first time, and the second they’d played aggressively, at their best. Erin had matched them, though she’d lost.

Now they knew. They knew it was Erin. And as Erin was white, she set the pace.

She picked up a pawn and stared at it. Silence. In the mind, and in her heart. Erin looked at the board. She loved the game. Whatever else changed, she still loved the game. She looked at the pawn. The room full of people, the watchers, all had disappeared. There was only silence. An empty stage. Then, for the first time in what felt like years, Erin began to play.

A simple song. A dance on a chess board only a few feet long. It started out as a quick shuffling of the feet. Pawn to D4. Clearing the throat. Pawn to D5.

Anyone could do the dance. Erin moved Knight to F3, and after a moment of hesitation in which the music skipped around aimlessly, the other side moved. Knight to F6.

Now the tune was picking up. Was there a violin in the orchestra? A cello? A piano began to play.

Bishop to F4. Now Erin could see the dance floor. She began a slow dance, tracing her steps slowly across the floor. The London System. That was the name of today's jig. But what would her opponent do next?

Hesitation. Erin looked across an empty floor and saw someone move. The Pawn moved to E6. Now they were in unknown territory.

The game shifted. Erin pushed a Pawn forwards. The music rose. Now there was an orchestra. She began a waltz across the floor.

And then? There was music. There was a dance. Her partner came at her across the chess board, flicking pieces towards her, grasping at the center. Erin danced back, sending her knights up, fortifying her position. Across the dance floor, her opponent spun and leapt to the same tune. Both sides mimicked the other. Knights and Pawns, building, edging together for superiority.

But no blood spilled, no pieces taken, not yet. Erin and her opponent met on the grand marble floor of the hall as the flutes and bows strained the air with building crescendos of sound. Not yet. Twenty moves in, and the board was still developing.

A Bishop came out. Erin tapped her foot and sent hers up. Mimicry. Mocking. Taunting. Waiting.

Then the black Pawn advanced and took hers. The first blow was struck. Erin reached out and tapped her opponent lightly. The music enveloped them both.

It wasn't like a dance. It was like a dance. It was just chess. What could you say about a game that was so static, so unchanging over the centuries? Nothing. Everything.

Erin walked through a different world. She played the game and lost. A second loss. She reset the board in a moment and played again. This time

she won. And then won again. And again. And again and—she lost the seventh game after that.

Time lost meaning. There was just the game. Erin had lived for twenty years. Of those twenty years, she had spent a lot of time breathing, sleeping, eating...but there was only one thing she had ever practiced. She'd spent more time playing chess than she had learning how to drive, how to cook, how to sing or dance or do anything else. This is what she knew.

This is what she had lived for. And her opponent was the same.

“You were lonely, weren't you?”

Erin whispered the words as she played. Win. Lose. Lose and then win again. She remembered. It was lonely, playing alone. It was hard to be by yourself. There was no one who could understand what you were doing when you played with other students over lunch. You had to search for people like you, but it was so hard to find someone who could see what you saw. The higher you went, the lonelier it got.

Erin had seen the clouds as a child and turned away. She'd come back as a teenager, climbed again because there was something beautiful she saw way up high. Now she touched the clouds and broke through. She danced on top of the world and showed the other player there was still sky above. Here we are. How far can we go? The game is endless. Come, dance with me.

Play with me.

She said only a few words through the games. A few words, from one lover of the game to the other. It was a simple message.

I'm sorry.

The reply was short, and simple.

I know. You are forgiven.

That was all. Erin stopped playing when her right hand began to hurt. She blinked, looked around, and realized all the lights in the room had gone out.

So, apparently, had the sun. It was close to midnight. No one was in the common room of the inn—or awake. Erin blinked around and realized

she'd been playing all day.

There was a groove in her flesh from where she'd pressed against the table's edge and her jaw hurt from resting so long on her propped up hand. Erin stretched and nearly fell over when she got up.

"That probably wasn't a productive use of time."

It wasn't an [Immortal Moment] that had consumed all this time. It wasn't a spell or anything else supernatural either. It was just obsession. Erin wandered into the kitchen, scarfed down half a pot's worth of Gnollish tortellini, huge, meat-stuffed, and oh so juicy, and then passed out on the floor.

A good day. If you didn't count the screaming.

[Magical Innkeeper Level 31!]

Was it because she picked a fight with the other innkeepers? Defended her home? Maybe it was because Erin had been doing good business lately. Accumulating experience points or however it went. Erin woke up blearily, wished she had a Skill that made it so she didn't have to sleep, and got on with the day.

"Are you going to play more chess today, Erin? Because if you are, we could use some more prepared food first. Not that I want to bother you, but uh..."

"No chess. Too much chess makes brain go poof."

Erin rested her head on the table, feeling as though someone tiny had just kicked her brain a few times. That was the thing people didn't understand. Chess was *exhausting*. Not physically, but mentally. Erin was surprised she'd kept up the same level of concentration for so long.

It was probably because she hadn't played for a while. She could put her brain into overdrive for a day, push her limits because of that. Because of

the *passion*. However, the next day was killing her. Erin dragged herself into the kitchen and did some easy cooking to pass the time.

Then she had a feeling in her stomach. It wasn't indigestion. Erin frowned and poked at her midriff, and then realized what the feeling was. She poked her head out into the common room.

"Bird?"

"I am here. Do you want me to shoot something?"

Bird stood to attention. He'd been coming by every day, as per Klbkch's orders for him. Erin asked if he knew whether the Hive could build her inn. Bird had no idea, so he wandered off to find Pawn.

He came back at midday with Pawn, a group of the painted Soldiers, and a score of Workers. Apparently the situation in the Hive was resolving itself. Erin conferred with Pawn about what she wanted and he had his Workers begin construction, warning Erin it would take several days to finish the work.

"We must remove parts of the roof and construct parts of the inn before lifting them up. We shall assemble scaffolding today and lay down a foundation. Tomorrow we shall knock that wall down and begin expansion."

He pointed at the west wall of Erin's inn. She frowned.

"Aw. I like that wall. Can you do the east side instead?"

Pawn stared at her. She laughed.

"Kidding!"

"Ah. I see."

Bird stared at the Workers hauling lumber up to the hill and then approached Pawn.

"Pawn, I would like my tower to be high. So I can shoot birds."

"Yes, Bird. I will make it high."

"Good."

Bird nodded a few times and lifted up his makeshift bow and arrows. Erin stared down at them and then glanced at Pawn.

“Do Antinium use bows, Pawn? Bird’s the first Antinium I’ve ever seen who uses one. But Ryoka says the Antinium used to use arrows in the first Antinium War.”

“Ah. Well, I do not know about the other Hives. Tersk tells me the Armored Antinium use crossbows, but our Hive does have a supply of bows and arrows. In limited quantities. There is little use for them underground, but Workers may use them in battle.”

“Oh. And they’re all like this?”

The bow Bird carried wasn’t *bad* per se, but it certainly was no masterwork. He’d made it from a single piece of wood, and used hemp for the string. The arrows were sharpened wood tips, without arrowheads. They were feathered, though. Some of them had incredible feathers. Bird was not a discriminating fletcher.

“This is a typical bow, yes. We are aware that it is not of high quality manufacture, but the Antinium usually only use bows against aerial foes. Hm. Perhaps I should see if Workers will work with my Soldiers. A few with bows could be...”

Pawn lapsed into thought as Bird tried to convince him to make his tower *extra* high. Erin had a thought from looking at Bird’s bow and found Ryoka. She was heading out to go stare at the wind with Ivolethe.

“We’re using chalk. Colored powder. The theory is that it’ll help me see the wind.”

Ryoka explained to Erin while Ivolethe quietly froze Pisces’ mug to the table. When the [Necromancer] went to pick it up, his hand stuck to the glass. Erin nodded as Pisces shouted in pain.

“Okay, but what about bows?”

“Excuse me?”

“Bird’s got a bow, but it’s a crappy one. It looks bad, anyways. Can you think of a better bow for him?”

Ryoka listened to Erin’s description of the bow and looked out the window to see Bird shooting arrows and arguing with Pawn over how high the tower needed to be given his range. She nodded.

“That’s a self bow. That means it’s one piece of wood. Easy to make, but you’re right that there are better kinds out there, and that’s not counting enchantments.”

“If you were going to recommend a bow...”

Ryoka pondered the question for a while.

“Recurves, composites, reflex...why not a recurve? It’s smaller than a longbow and it’s got a punch. I’ve seen Gnolls using them—they’re good hunters. Why not ask Krshia if she has one?”

“I think I’ll do just that.”

Erin smiled at Ryoka and went to pull some gold coins out from her savings. On the way she met Lyonette.

“Erin, look, *look!* It’s moving!”

She had a bowl in her hands. And in the bowl—practically hanging off the sides of the bowl was a bee. Erin knew Lyonette had the bee. She had seen many bees, most of them dead. She just wasn’t prepared for *this* bee in her face.

“Gah! Why is it so *big?*”

This bee was twice the size of a regular Ashfire bee, and those were already the size of a fat hand. Lyonette beamed.

“I think it’s because I was feeding it all that jelly! Isn’t it amazing? Look, you can see it’s moving about a bit!”

The bee was indeed moving. The pupa had developed into distinct features, and now it was *twitching* a bit. Erin stared at the bee and edged away. Why was Lyonette not bothered by it? Oh, right. She killed bees and stole their honey every week.

“Is it—shriveling up?”

“I think so. It’s starting to grow little hairs, look!”

Mrsha was excitedly sniffing at the bee. Erin backed away towards the kitchen, hands raised. Drassi was trying to hide behind Ryoka and Ryoka was trying to prevent Ivolethe from attacking the bee.

“It looks great Lyonette, really. But why don’t you put it in your room before Ivolethe attacks? Let me know if the bee starts to move. Actually, let me know the *instant* it moves, okay? In fact...I’ll go down to the city right now and buy a leash.”

“A leash?”

Lyonette blinked at Erin. Erin nodded.

“Yes. A leash. Because you’re going to leash your bee, right?”

“I—don’t know. I hadn’t thought about it. I was just raising it—Apista, I mean. I don’t know if I can control her.”

Erin stared at Ryoka. The other girl shrugged. Erin turned back to Lyonette with a smile.

“Let’s find that out soon, okay? Great! Uh...keep it—her—away from the Antinium too.”

Both Pawn and Bird had noticed the bee Lyonette was holding and were staring at it. They looked innocently away as Lyonette glanced over.

That done with, Erin grabbed gold coins and silver ones and rushed into Liscor. She found Krshia selling salt by the sack in her shop. The Gnoll looked happier than she had in ages.

“Erin. It is good you are here, yes? After your last visit Brunkr seems better. Hrr. Much better, yes. Will you visit him? He has been asking about you.”

“Sure! I’ll visit him tonight. Listen, Krshia, do you have a, uh, leash? And collar? I’ve got a bee that’s about to hatch and I do *not* want it flying around before I know if it’s an angry bee or a nice one.”

Krshia blinked at Erin, but she nodded when she heard about Apista.

“There are dog leashes which can be adjusted. And collars. One of my cousins in the city, he breeds dogs. I think he will have some that can be used.”

“Gnolls have dogs as pets?”

Erin paused. She’d seen some dogs in Celum, but not in Liscor. Krshia shrugged.

“It is not too common. Some Gnoll tribes breed dogs to be eaten or as pets, but pets are difficult to raise in a city, yes? But some Drakes like pets. Gnolls have an easy time training dogs anyways. We are pack leaders to them.”

She grinned toothily. Erin looked at Krshia and thought that if Gnolls ever made it to Earth, Cesar Millan would probably be out of a job.

“Cool. Great. Also—bows. Do you have, uh, recurving bows?”

“Recurving? You mean...recurve?”

“Yeah. All the curves. Or...composite? Reflex? I’m asking for a friend.”

The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] nodded.

“I shoot a recurve bow myself. I know a very good [Bowyer], and I will introduce him to you, yes? He is part of my tribe so he will give you a discount. What bow did you want? Enchanted ones are very expensive.”

“Uh...I want something that’s good to shoot birds with. I have money.”

Erin looked pleadingly at Krshia. The Gnoll sighed and smiled, and made time to go with Erin to the said bowyer and select a fine recurve bow made of yew. It cost a metaphorical arm and a leg, too.

“Twenty six gold coins?”

The bowyer nodded, looking proud of his work. Erin stared at the bow dubiously. Krshia coughed and motioned Erin aside so she could talk to her.

“It is worth hundreds, yes? Yew is good wood. Some say the best. And the bows are hard to make. This is a price at its base—without counting labor, only parts. A bow for this price, it would be four hundred gold coins if shipped far north, or to a place where there are no good bow makers. Enchanted bows may be worth more, but this is his finest work.”

“Wait, then why am I paying—”

“A favor. For Ryoka’s friend, yes? The debt is honored. And Erin Solstice and Ryoka Griffin are both of the same tribe.”

The [Bowyer] nodded at Krshia, smiling widely. She winced as Erin stared at her.

“What did Ryoka do?”

“She did my tribe a favor. One beyond worth. Friendship was the price. And this—is an act of friendship. So we will charge you for only the cost of the wood and transportation. As friends.”

Erin thought about this. She dug in her money pouch and pulled out gold coins.

“Deal. And I’ll tell everyone that this is the best shop for bows, okay?”

Krshia and the [Bowyer] smiled as Erin put the coins on the table. Erin reached for some silver to account for the last gold coin and pulled out the odd coin she’d received. She stared at it. So did Krshia.

“What is that coin, Erin Solstice?”

“This? Oh it’s...I don’t really know. I got it from one of my customers. Do you know how much it’s worth, Krshia? Or what it is?”

“Hmm. Hm. I have not seen a coin such as this.”

Krshia took the coin from Erin with careful paws and held it up to the light. She sniffed at it, wrinkled her nose, and sniffed again.

“It is ancient. I can tell you that. It smells of the earth, as if it were buried long. But the material...hm. Brathiak, lend me a knife, yes? Good steel, I think.”

But when Krshia went to obtain a sliver of the coin, the knife she was using failed to scratch the surface. She applied a lot of strength and nearly sliced her own paw. In the end she handed the coin back to Erin, shaking her head.

“Strong metal. I do not know what it is made of Erin. But it must come from an ancient kingdom, yes? It may be worth much to a collector, but I could not tell you the value. Perhaps a Dwarf could, if you met one.”

“Okay. I’ll hang on to it.”

Erin slipped the coin back into her pouch and paid for the bow. She carried it out of the bowyer’s shop with profuse thanks, and began walking back to her inn.

There was something odd about Gnolls. Most of them didn’t say much to Erin in passing—they just sniffed and nodded, which was their way. They could smell if Erin had had her period, if she’d had indigestion while

pooping, and they could probably smell what she'd eaten for breakfast and *when* she'd eaten it. They were also, thankfully, unconcerned with the Human body.

Some male Drakes tended to whistle and make comments at female Drakes as they passed. Humans did the same thing, which Erin didn't like, but Gnolls just sniffed or growled at each other so it didn't bother her. Except for today. Today, as Gnolls saw Erin going down the street she could have been the hottest thing walking.

For both genders. Gnolls kept coming up to Erin and asking about the bow.

"Hrr. Yew, yes? Would you mind if I felt it?"

"Good construction. Do you shoot?"

"We should hunt together sometime. A bow like that deserves use."

The lesson for the day was that Gnolls were weird about bows. Mrsha sat up and stared when she brought the bow into her inn. Bird stared when she brought it to him. She thought he would have burst into tears if he could.

"This bow is for me?"

"Yes! I got it from a friend of Krshia's for almost nothing! I'll uh, give it to you as advance payment for guarding my inn, okay?"

Bird was shaking his head as he felt the bow with trembling hands.

"It is too much. Too beautiful. I cannot take it."

"Yes, you can."

Erin made him lift the bow and try it out. The first arrow that Bird shot went halfway *through* the wall of her inn. Erin made him try the bow outside after that.

"Good bow."

Halrac had come back with his group early from the dungeon. He was rubbing healing potion over a cut on his arm. He nodded at the bow and Erin saw him lift his bow up to see.

“I use a reflex bow made from spriggan wood. Highly flexible and enchanted for longer range and accuracy. It’s the best bow for close quarters and sneaking around, but you got your friend a good bow. It must have cost a small fortune.”

Bird turned to Erin, stricken. She waved her hands.

“No, no. It was a favor. That’s how I got it so cheap.”

“Some favor. Gnolls love bows.”

Halrac grunted. Erin nodded.

“Yeah...I owe Ryoka for that one. But that’s what [Innkeepers] do, right? We trade in favors and good will and stuff. Speaking of which...can you do me a favor right now?”

The [Scout] eyed Erin.

“What?”

“Can you teach Bird how to shoot the bow properly? I mean, I don’t want to insult Bird, but you’re a master [Scout], right? Maybe you can show him a few tricks? Skills? How to make an arrow?”

Halrac glanced at Bird. Erin knew he didn’t like the Antinium that much, but Bird’s obsession with bows and shooting things seemed to win the grumpy man over. He nodded.

“I can do that. Come on, you. Let’s find something to shoot at.”

He strode out of the inn. Bird alternatively bowed to Erin and ran to follow. Lyonette stared at them and then looked at Erin.

“That was really nice.”

“Yeah. Well...I’m uh, going to get you something too. A sword. Or a mace. Hammer. What kind of weapon would you like if you used one? Do you use one?”

“A sword? *Me?*”

“Didn’t you say you wanted more classes? I’ll get you a sword and you can practice fighting, okay?”

Erin poked at her upset stomach while Lyonette gaped at her.

“But I—I’ve never held a sword before! Ever! I wouldn’t know where to begin! Erin, I’d need a teacher—”

“I’ve got one in mind. Maybe. I’ll let you know. Sorry, I’ve got to talk to Octavia.”

Erin opened the door to Celum and saw Octavia selling a bunch of matches over the counter. Erin stared at the crude match boxes and saw Octavia accepting silver coins for them. She felt...that was a rip off. The [Alchemist] was grinning when she turned to Erin.

“Can you believe it, Erin? I’m getting rich! All thanks to your little Gnoll cub! I’ve been selling shipments of matches to the [Merchants]—people want what I’ve got! It’s only a matter of time before other [Alchemists] start copying my design—hah, obviously—but I’ve leveled up three times from developing the matches!”

She grinned in delight at Erin. Erin nodded, smiling, and poked at her stomach again. The feeling hadn’t gone away since this morning.

“Great. Do you want another job? Aside from perfecting the penicillin, by the way. I’ll need some of that too if you’ve got more.”

“The mold? Leveled up from that too. Sure!”

Octavia laughed as she brought out some of the mold poultice she’d mixed up for Erin a few days ago. Erin carefully took the jar of paste and passed Octavia a few coins.

“It’s not completely effective, you know.”

“I know. I’m trying to isolate the exact stuff Ryoka was mentioning. I’ll work on it. Now, what’s the other thing you wanted to talk about?”

“Healing slimes. And I want pepper potions, more healing potions, and whatever other alchemist weapons you’ve got. Or any you can get.”

“Well of course, I can get you some pepper potions—brewed up a batch just the other day. And I’ve got a tripvine bag—I *could* see if anyone else is selling a burn blast mixture, although that’ll cost—wait, back up. What was the first thing you said?”

Octavia frowned as her brain caught up to her mouth. Erin was busy pulling potions off the shelf. She dumped them in front of Octavia.

“Healing. Slimes. Can you make a slime? Can you make one made out of healing potions? Can you make one for me?”

Octavia stared at Erin.

“I have no idea. But a healing slime sounds...very profitable. Or it could run me out of business. Why don’t you talk to one of your [Mage] friends about that and uh, tell me if it works?”

“Will do! How’s fifteen gold coins for the lot sound?”

“*Fifteen*—hey, wait!”

The Stitch-Girl saw all the potions and items Erin was trying to walk out with. She rushed out from behind her counter to stop Erin.

“That’s worth *way* more than fifteen gold coins! Even without my usual markup! You can’t just take them, Erin!”

“Well, that’s all the room I’ve got in my budget. Look, I need this stuff, Octavia.”

“Yes, I understand that by you trying to take them. *But—*”

“Who told you how to make match sticks?”

Erin stared at Octavia. The [Alchemist] opened her mouth, and then closed it.

“But—”

“Just this once. One debt paid, how about that? And I’ll give you more ideas in the future.”

“But—I—”

“I really need these, Octavia. Please?”

Octavia looked like she might have an aneurysm as she stared at the potions piled up in Erin’s arms. She looked around for inspiration, and stared at the boxes of matches on display in her shop. She gnawed at her lip and nodded.

“Just once. Then we’re square, got it?”

“Charge me as much as you want another time. Thanks!”

Erin left the shop and carefully lined up all the potions in one of her pantries in the kitchen. Lyonette stared at the bottles and bags in awe.

“How did you pay for all of that? Is there *any* money left over?”

She looked almost afraid to ask. Erin nodded.

“I got it for cheap. Again. I’m cashing in favors here.”

“Why?”

Lyonette looked curiously at Erin. The [Innkeeper] hesitated and poked at her stomach. Same feeling.

“Call it a hunch. Look, I’ve got to go into Liscor for one more thing. Can you tell Ceria, Typhenous, Revi, Pisces, Moore...you know, all the mages that I want their help? The key word is ‘slimes’. Also, ‘healing’. Maybe ‘acid’, too.”

“Slimes? Healing? Acid? Okay, but I think they’re busy...”

“Tell them I’m calling in my favors if I have them! I also want to talk with Pisces about the undead! Tell him he’s not in trouble so he doesn’t run!”

Erin called out and left the inn at a trot. She had one more destination that day.

“Thank you for doing this, Erin.”

Brunkr sat in Krshia’s apartment as Erin applied the poultice that Octavia had given her. She spread it gently on his infected arm, trying not to make the Gnoll wince.

“How’s it feel? Better?”

“Much.”

Brunkr gingerly flexed his arm as he stared at the red gash in his arm. It had stopped leaking pus. The first few molds that Octavia had managed to isolate hadn’t done much for him, but this one was effective—or the honey

and regular cleaning were doing their job. Erin had checked on Brunkr all week, and he was looking better each day.

Now the gash was actually healing. Brunkr was also well enough to be hungry, and he'd eaten half a cow already, or so Krshia told Erin. He seemed fit again as well.

"Have you been working out?"

"I have been running. It does not bother my arm, and I am restless, now that I feel better."

Brunkr grinned at Erin. He let her wrap his arm carefully with the bandage she'd prepared and then offered her something to eat. Since Erin had forgotten to have lunch, she had some of the sliced raw meat the Gnolls loved so much. Someday she was going to get sick from it, but it tasted really good.

"I'm glad. If you keep healing like this, Ryoka thinks you might be able to use a healing potion soon."

"I would not risk it after last time."

Brunkr flexed his arm and grimaced at the memory. He nodded to the wound as he spoke to Erin, smiling at her. He had become very welcoming and hospitable as of late.

"A wound like this—if I take care with it, I may still use my other arm, yes? Why not let it heal with time and train in the meanwhile? I feel able to practice with a sword—this is my shield arm."

"Oh, right. You're a [Warrior], aren't you?"

"I aspire to be a [Knight], in truth. But the class requires something I do not have. Until then, I am simply a [Warrior]. One of the best in my tribe."

He said that without modesty, but without bragging as well. Erin remembered Brunkr fighting when he'd attacked Toren and she had to agree that he was pretty good. He'd taken a lot of her punches without falling down.

"If you want to practice, I have an offer for you. Would you be willing to uh, go by my inn and train Lyonette? I want to let her learn to be a [Warrior], if she's willing."

Brunkr froze. He stared at Erin.

“Me? Train Lyonette?”

“Yeah. And maybe Bird too. If he wants to learn how to fight with a sword, that is. I don’t want to learn—I use a frying pan and a knife. But some tips would be good. Maybe you can make up with Mrsha too. She feels bad about what she did.”

Brunkr stood up and paced about slowly while Erin snacked on more of the meat. What did the Gnolls call it again? Ssarish? No, that was the Drake version. She’d forgotten.

“Teach—I can teach. But why? I would not mind, but...it is an odd request coming from you. My Aunt tells me today you bought an expensive bow for your guard.”

“And I stocked up on potions. I’m going to buy a burn blast potion too, if anyone’s selling.”

The Gnoll sat, staring at Erin.

“A powerful item. Silver-rank adventurers use that, as do Gold-ranked ones. Why would you need such a thing?”

Erin hesitated. She poked at her stomach and Brunkr noticed.

“Are you feeling sick? I cut the meat for the Rashgr myself. It should not be—”

“No, I’m not feeling sick from the food. It’s something else.”

Erin shook her head. She’d been feeling the sensation all morning. She looked at Brunkr and decided to confide in him.

“Actually, Brunkr, I’ve been feeling worried all day. I felt a bit worried yesterday, actually, but then I played chess and...but I felt it today as well.”

“Felt what?”

“Uneasy. As if...something’s coming. I know Pawn has his Soldiers and there’s Gold-rank adventurers in my inn, but they’re not there all the time. And the dungeon is dangerous—Relc is always talking about it. So...I’m just taking precautions. I’m going to talk to Pisces about one more thing he can do, and try to cross-breed slimes.”

Brunkr stared at Erin. She knew she wasn't making too much sense, but she just felt strongly that she should be doing something. Her head turned.

The Gnoll saw Erin looking around the room, and then look towards one of Krshia's walls. There was nothing there, but Brunkr knew that Erin was pointed northeast from the position of the setting sun in the sky.

"There's something...coming. Something bad, I think. I just feel uneasy."

"Hrr. If you say so, I will agree. But what? Could it be the Goblin Lord? The monsters from the dungeon? Something else?"

Erin shrugged. But she looked uneasy. Brunkr had seldom seen Erin looking nervous, but now she did.

"I don't know. But I just feel like I should be ready. Like we should all be ready."

She reached out and pushed the half-full jar of poultice towards Brunkr.

"If you want to help, come tomorrow. Or tonight. And tell me where to buy a sword. I don't have that much money left after the bow and potions, but Ryoka can lend me some money. I'll talk to the Horns of Hammerad—see if they're ready too."

"Ready for what? A war?"

Erin hesitated. The young woman looked around, and Brunkr saw her eyes fix on that same spot to the northeast.

"Bad things, Brunkr. Just...bad things."

"We have arrived."

Venitra, first-born of Az'kerash's creations and loyal servant to her master, paused as she stared at the distant walls of the city. They weren't as tall as she had expected, but then, she had seen the Walled Cities up close and few structures could match the memory of their colossal fortifications.

In any case, the city was not important. She drew the travelling cloak tighter around her undead form. The white bone from which her entire body was made—an armored body that any Dullahan would envy, but far stronger, woven with spells crafted by her loving master himself—was concealed from any eyes at a distance. She had to stay hidden.

She was not here for war. Not yet. She had to find someone. The Runner. For that, she would traverse the world. It had been an arduous journey getting here, but at last they had arrived. Venitra, and—

Ijvani.

Venitra turned her head to regard her companion. Ijvani usually travelled in a cloak of woven shadows, a production of magic that protected her from sight as well as attack. However, she too had exchanged her usual garb for a simple traveler's cloak. It was just as well no one was around, however. A single look into either undead woman's hoods would reveal a nightmare.

Two kinds of nightmares, in fact. Where Venitra's hood would have revealed a sculpted face of bone, something similar to a Golem but far more unsettling, Ijvani's cloak concealed a different secret. An unsettling one. A thought—inspiration from the Necromancer's mind given form.

Two burning golden eyes stared at Venitra. They were placed in the hollow, grinning skull of a skeleton. That was what Ijvani was. A skeleton mage. No ordinary mage, though. Her magic was on par with any Gold-rank adventurer. Yet even that did not set her apart. It was her body.

Bone, yes. Reanimated, yes. But her bones were not the pristine white of Venitra's form, or the yellow of bones left to rot. Instead, Ijvani's bones *shone*. They shone black.

Black iron. Ijvani was not as heavy as Venitra, but she weighed far more than she should. Her entire body was a kind of armor, and carved into the metal were glowing runes, symbols of destruction. She and Venitra were made for battle, made to kill, each in their own way. They would find the Courier, find the Runner, find who she had told and slay them all.

“It is time, Ijvani.”

The skeleton mage nodded. Venitra strode towards the city of Liscor, preparing herself. To find their quarry, they would have to search. Hide themselves. The Drakes and Gnolls could be tricked. This would be the first city they searched through, for any trace of the Runner's passing. After that, would they go north? Only time would tell. Would their master grow weary of waiting and contact them? Venitra longed to hear his voice. Perhaps—

"Ah, Venitra."

Ijvani's voice stopped Venitra. The bone-white woman looked back at her companion, annoyed.

"What is it? We are wasting time."

The black skeleton was consulting a bloody map they'd found on the corpse of someone they'd horrifically slaughtered on the road here. She was peering at the city and at the mountains. She turned and stared south.

"Remember that mountain we climbed over?"

"Yes. What of it?"

"I think...we shouldn't have done that. According to this map, we're not at Liscor."

"We're not?"

Venitra stared at Ijvani. The skeleton nodded.

"This...is Esthelm. Liscor is that way."

She pointed. Venitra stared. She stared at Ijvani, the map, and then towards Liscor. She sighed. Ijvani looked at her.

"You really should have brought Kerash. He knows this continent far better than I do."

"I brought you because you and Oom are our best trackers."

Venitra's face contorted into a scowl as she looked accusingly at Ijvani. The skeleton mage nodded.

"At tracking. But I need a quarry to locate them by magic. Oom needs a scent. We have neither. I'm not good at reading maps on the other hand, or signs. You're supposed to be our master's most competent creation. Why can't you ever find where we're going?"

Venitra shook her head.

“Shut up. We’re leaving.”

She started walking towards Liscor, her heavy tread cracking the earth. She’d gone ten feet when Ijvani called out after her.

“I lied. Liscor is that way.”

She pointed in the other direction. Venitra stopped, stared at Ijvani. Her tone was thick with malice.

“If you were not our master’s creation, I would destroy you right now.”

“You can try. I am the greatest skeleton to ever walk the earth. So my master designed me.”

She couldn’t argue with that. Venitra stomped towards Liscor. When she found that accursed Runner, she was going to rip her toes off one by one. To start with.

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The Wandering Inn was full today as well. That was unusual, at least to Erin, Lyonette, and anyone who knew the inn well. Erin had developed an inn based around the idea of ‘just enough people to survive’ for quite some time. To have an inn that was actually bustling was surprising.

However, word had gotten out that Erin’s inn was a place with excellent cooking, fast service, interesting things, and most importantly, magical food. That, combined with the influx of adventurers into Liscor meant that her inn was a hotspot. Having a magical door leading to Celum helped.

Indeed, it would be more surprising if Erin’s inn hadn’t become so famous. After all, Drakes and Gnolls might not like Humans that much, but who could resist going for a five minute walk and then popping into *another city* to see what the smelly Humans were up to? And when you were tired of that, you could have a drink or quick bite on the way back. You didn’t have to wait—the inn had food pre-prepared that only needed warming up before it was hot and ready to eat!

Some might go as far as to say that Erin’s inn was now a huge concern for the other inns in Liscor and Celum. Erin’s current set of Skills had made her inn three times as attractive as every other inn. Well, except for Peslas’ inn, the Tailless Thief. It was still a byword for Drakes in Liscor, but it was specialized. Erin’s inn accepted everyone.

Everyone. From [Farmers] who stopped by for some food and a break from the cold, to [Guardsmen] and [Guardswomen] from Celum and Liscor who had learned that Erin had a soft spot for their kind. They sat and dined and laughed at tables next to [Merchants] who might be playing games of Chess and keeping an ear open for saleable news. However, these were all minority populations. The clientele that dominated Erin’s inn at the moment were all of a different kind.

They stood out. They were the insane, the suicidal, and the reckless. Or, they could be deliberate, cautious, and mindful of the socioeconomic value of their class and be willing to take calculated risks for ample rewards. Either way, there was a broad name for them.

Adventurers.

Right now they were filling most of Erin's tables, staring at the Antinium Workers who were measuring the walls, whilst the adventurers shouted for drinks, and tried to eat plates full of Erin's magical cooking. It was excellent stuff all had to admit—downing a plate could make you stronger, tougher, or immune to the biting cold winds. However, it was also regarded as a punishment game of sorts; Erin still hadn't perfected the recipe, and more than a few weak-stomached adventurers were swallowing their snail-based Strength Soufflé hard.

Yes, a few silver coins and you could be strong enough to wrestle a Corusdeer with your hands—so long as you minded the horns. That was a great service—and a danger. Halrac lifted up a glob of the blue Scale Soup he'd been served and stared at it grimly. He opened his mouth, swallowed the spoonful, and scraped the wooden bowl without a change in his expression.

He didn't have to. Revi, watching him, was making enough faces for the both of them.

"That is *disgusting*, Halrac. How can you stand eating that?"

"You're eating it too, Revi. No objections."

"I'd rather you poked a few needles through my head!"

"Eat."

Halrac pushed the second bowl over to Revi. The [Summoner] Stitch Girl picked up a spoon reluctantly. She eyed the soup and kept complaining, much to Halrac's displeasure.

"Why can't I eat the Strength Soufflé? That at least looks palatable."

"It's got snails in it."

"Ew! How does Erin serve this stuff?"

"Because it works. Eat."

Revi did so, reluctantly. She kept making faces, although the blue stuff really wasn't that bad tasting. Taste-wise, it was actually pleasant. It just had a terrible appearance, texture, consistency, and smell.

“Remind me why we’re eating this stuff? What about the Corusdeer Scramble? That tastes *good* and it would keep us warm.”

Halrac opened his mouth to snap at her, but a big head leaned over and interrupted him. Ulrien, the mild-mannered leader of Griffon Hunt, raised two fingers as he spoke.

“Two reasons, Revi. One, Erin’s enchantments only work one at a time. Second, if it’s a choice between the three she’s offering—strength, defense, or cold resistance, we’re all getting the defense.”

“Lots of these young adventurers are getting the Soufflé.”

“Yes, they are.”

Halrac glanced around. Erin’s Strength Soufflé could be seen on almost every table. Who wouldn’t like to be stronger for a few hours? It was a great feeling, and it was a fun trick to challenge a friend to an arm-wrestling competition and then give them a sore arm. Some of the adventurers wearing cheap leather armor and bearing shabby weapons were flexing their arms and grinning at each other. They’d probably never been able to afford an enchantment before and were savoring the moment.

“Newbies.”

At least Revi could understand what the rest of her group was thinking. The Stitch Girl shook her head as she spooned soup into her mouth. She grimaced, but for once it wasn’t about the food.

“I wonder how many of them will get killed because they think they’re invincible? Does Erin know how many of these idiots are going out and getting slaughtered by monsters?”

“If she doesn’t, don’t tell her.”

Halrac looked warningly at Revi. The Stitch Girl glared at him as she took a drink from her mug. It was no secret within Griffon Hunt that Halrac had a soft spot for Erin...in his own peculiar way. She opened her mouth to needle him, changed her mind when Ulrien looked at her, and gave up.

“If Bronze-rank adventurers are dying, it’s because they overestimate their abilities or underestimate their opponents. That’s how it’s always been. Smart adventurers will know that these enchantments are a useful tool, not an all-powerful spell.”

Revi and Halrac nodded silently. Ulrien glanced around and grunted. His passive face turned into a frown.

“Still, there *are* a lot of them.”

The three members of Griffon Hunt looked around. The inn was *packed* with adventurers. As they watched, a group of them tossed some coins onto their table and made for the door to Celum. They were probably going to exterminate some monsters nearby. Another group of armed warriors were eating the Corusdeer Scramble with pleasure while they tried to cram a hot Soufflé into their packs for later. *That* was amusing to watch.

However...there was a large group in the center of the room that looked ready for a fight *now*. They were checking each other’s gear, and Halrac’s keen eyes placed them squarely as a mix of Silver-rank and Bronze-rank adventurers. There were about twenty packed into four tables, and one of them stood up with a mug in his hands.

“We will descend into the dungeon through the rift today! Today, Petra’s Bane, Twinfold Daggers, and...”

Halrac tuned the speaker out. He didn’t need to hear the rest, or listen to the adventurers cheering their leader. He turned to Revi and Ulrien.

“Another group heading into the dungeon? Are they insane?”

Revi and Ulrien just stared at Halrac. The [Scout] didn’t really need an answer either. He understood the thinking of the cheering adventurers, though he condemned it.

After the wild success of Vuliel Drae, the wild fervor surrounding Liscor’s Dungeon had reignited itself. It had gone out for a while. A new dungeon was one thing, but the first few rooms were so dangerous that it was a death sentence for anyone but an experienced Silver or Gold-rank team to attempt those first few steps.

But this new entry into the dungeon through the rift in the snow? That was something else. And Vuliel Drae had come out with a weapon worthy of a Gold-rank adventurer, or perhaps a Named Adventurer. The Mace of Howling had sold for thousands of gold coins already, and ignited the passions of every adventurer within three hundred miles. The thought was on everyone’s mind. If one group could find a weapon of that caliber from

one scouting attempt, what treasures were lost below? Just one such item could set up an adventurer for life.

Halrac was familiar with that way of thinking. He'd been in the same boat over a decade ago, a poor Bronze-rank adventurer scrabbling for work. However, he and the rest of Griffon Hunt realized the danger in that line of thought. Liscor's Dungeon was not to be underestimated.

The adventuring group was listening to another impassioned speech, from one of the other team leaders. Halrac was familiar with that as well. Adventurers were people too; they needed to psych themselves up before they risked their lives. He turned back to the rest of his group, and addressed the trio sitting at the table next to theirs.

"Alright, where did we go wrong?"

"Excuse me?"

Jelaqua Ivirith looked up from her bowl of Scale Soup. The other two members of her group, the Halfseekers, looked up as well. All three were eating from their bowls of blue sludge. They'd been laughing and trying to play chess together, but Halrac's comment made them sit up.

The Halfseekers. Ulrien gave Halrac a reproving glance for interrupting their conversation. Halrac didn't acknowledge it. They were supposed to be working together. The Halfseekers and Griffon Hunt had agreed to join forces to tackle this dungeon. If they were a team, they should talk like one.

"I'm asking where we went wrong. Why are all these Bronze-rank teams getting ahead of *us*?"

Halrac growled as he reached for a bowl of walnuts. That was Erin's newest attempt to add 'cool stuff' to her inn. He cracked one of the walnuts one-handed and flicked the pieces into a second bowl. Jelaqua and the Halfseekers turned obligingly to listen as the [Scout] aired his grievances.

"We have more levels in our team than that entire group does between them. How are we still struggling to get past the first set of trapped rooms?"

The other adventurers shared a look. Jelaqua edged her chair forwards and then leaned back in it until it rested on the table behind her. She looked incredibly pleased at this development; Halrac thought it was juvenile.

But that was the way the Halfseekers worked. Griffon Hunt prided itself on being a group that valued teamwork, planning, and serious commitment in the field. By contrast, the Halfseekers...not two seconds ago, Seborn and Jelaqua had had a contest seeing who could down their bowl of Scale Soup faster. They were too relaxed for Halrac's liking. However, he had to admit that they were competent.

Both groups knew of each other's reputation. They were sometimes competitors, sometimes adversaries in the same field. So when Moore spoke, Halrac listened.

"I feel bad for these new adventurers, Halrac. I do not feel they're getting ahead of us. Rather, I'm worried about their inexperience. Vuliel Drae's success was a mistake. They survived the dungeon thanks to the mysterious masked swordswoman, not through their own efforts, or so I understand."

"Yeah. Her."

Halrac grunted. He'd heard the stories too. There was a Named Adventurer down in the dungeon, was there? Someone who'd gotten past all the traps and entered the dungeon without anyone seeing? Hardly likely, but Vuliel Drae had sworn on truth spells it was true.

One of the Halfseekers seemed to believe in the swordswoman's existence, at any rate. Seborn leaned forwards, and Halrac glanced at the armored half of the Drowned Man's face, noting the way the crustacean shell blended with his skin. Seborn seemed immune to the scrutiny as he sipped from his mug of water and spoke.

"It has to be true. The dungeon is too dangerous for Silver-rank adventurers to survive a trip down there without being overwhelmed. We've all gone head-to-head with the traps. We teamed up because they're that bad. This dungeon's not like the other ones. It's nasty."

Nasty. That was one word for it. The other Gold-rank adventurers shifted in their seats. Ulrien nodded.

"I've been in several dungeons before. Not deep, and not when they were just discovered, but I've seen where the traps used to be and fought their monster populations. They're nothing like this dungeon. This dungeon feels like it wasn't meant just to hide treasure. It feels like..."

“Like a huge trap. Yeah. I’m calling it. This one’s a vengeance dungeon.”

Jelaqua drained her mug and slammed it down on the table. The Selphid sighed and pushed her bowl back. Halrac studied her dead features silently. He was in agreement.

“Vengeance dungeon?”

Revi was confused. Halrac glanced at her and remembered that she was new. Ulrien and Halrac had hired her and Typhenous into Griffon Hunt, and both [Mages] were competent, but Revi wasn’t nearly as old or experienced as the other three men. He let Ulrien explain.

“Dungeons come in several types, Revi. I know [Mages] study which empire built them and their composition and so on—adventurers have a simpler system. Dungeons are either for containment, future generations, or as an act of vengeance.”

“Interesting terms. What’s the difference between the three?”

Halrac pushed Revi’s bowl of unfinished soup towards her as Ulrien explained. The Stitch Girl sighed, but ate as Ulrien talked.

“Containment dungeons are meant to contain something. Simple enough; it could be a threat, a natural resource too valuable to let someone else get ahold of...I once saw a dungeon that had been built solely to combat Vampires. It was more like a fortress that made use of light-based traps and spells.”

“Okay. Then future generations...?”

Jelaqua grinned.

“Dungeons built with traps that test people entering. Say an empire’s about to collapse. Well, they want to leave something behind, right? Only, the people who build the dungeons want their shiny magical artifacts to go to the deserving. So they build a dungeon which only the best can enter. That way, future generations can follow a handy map and get through the traps, or a brave adventuring group can fight their way through and retrieve past glories. Just a way for the previous generations to help us out.”

“I get it. Then a vengeance dungeon’s what happens when...what? You have angry ancestors?”

Revi frowned. Jelaqua nodded. She grimaced.

“Yep. They’re what you get when the empire or civilization *doesn’t* feel like being nice to future generations. So they build a dungeon with their best artifacts sealed away—I mean, where else would you put them?—but they put the *nastiest* traps and monster eggs down there. So when someone cracks the lid on the dungeon, a thousand ravening Crelers crawl out and eat their faces off.”

“Great. And that’s what we’re up against? Remind me why we’re not hunting Griffins? That’s what I signed up for.”

The Stitch Girl pushed her empty bowl back, looking upset. Ulrien sighed, but Halrac decided to answer this time. He saw Ulrien’s warning look, but he could be encouraging too.

“Just because the dungeon’s designed to kill, it doesn’t mean there’s no point entering it, Revi. We’re looking for treasure, and it’s down there. The mace is proof of that. The only difference is that this dungeon’s out to get us. So we need to be wary. And fast. Which is why I’m asking why these amateurs are—”

The [Scout] broke off when he realized someone was standing behind him. He turned in his seat and glared at the leader of the adventurers he’d just been insulting. The young Drake must have come over and he’d been too busy complaining to notice. Halrac scowled, more upset that he’d let his guard down than anything else.

“What?”

“Uh, pardon me, but you’re Halrac the Grim, aren’t you?”

Halrac *hated* that name. He growled at the Drake, eyeing him from head to tail.

“So?”

The young Drake was wearing iron armor, but he had a steel sword. He was probably Silver-rank, but Halrac would put him on the lower end of that spectrum. Still, he was bold enough to approach the Gold-rank adventurers, which most Human adventurers wouldn’t have the courage for. He smiled nervously as Halrac stared at him.

“Sorry, but you might have heard. We’re heading into the dungeon—we uh, were hoping you had some words for us? Some advice, maybe? Tips?”

The other Gold-rank adventurers shifted. Revi raised her eyebrows and shook her head, not trying to hide her incredulity. Ulrien sighed. Drake and Gnoll adventurers clearly weren’t like Human ones. No group of adventurers up north would be this bold—they were keenly aware of the hierarchy and unwritten rules, one of which was not to bother the veterans.

Not that Griffon Hunt was into hazing adventurers. But asking for advice? Halrac just stared at the young Drake. He was ready to tell him no and turn away, but Jelaqua sat up. She smiled and gave voice to the feeling shared between all the Gold-rank adventurers.

“I’d be ready to run, kids. Maybe write a letter to your loved ones, if you have any. Best advice? Don’t go down. You’re going to die.”

She nodded at the listening adventurers, who’d gone silent. Jelaqua gave them a friendly smile, her pale, dead lips at once friendly and horrific.

“A strength enchantment’s no good down in the dungeon, not against traps or monsters ambushing you. Don’t go down. Find another quest, level up, and come back when you’re all Silver-rank, or better yet, Gold. We wouldn’t go into the dungeon through the rift, and we know what we’re about. That’s my advice. Take it or leave it.”

The inn had gone silent at Jelaqua’s words. Halrac looked around and saw a lot of the adventurers looking nervous. But one of them, drunk on bravado and alcohol, raised his voice.

“Hah! You’re just afraid we’ll get to the treasure first! What kind of an adventurer’s a Selphid, anyways? A body stealing coward doesn’t know anything about Drake bravery!”

“Or Gnoll courage!”

Another adventurer raised his paw, and the other adventurers around him cheered. Jelaqua shrugged, looking slightly hurt, but more resigned. Seborn nudged her as she sat and Moore frowned, which was as good as one of Halrac’s scowls.

Selphids got that reaction. But this was passing beyond rude. Jelaqua was a Gold-rank adventurer. The Drake leader shouted down his

companions, and turned to Halrac, smiling as if *they* were friends.

“What about you, Mister Halrac?”

“You heard her. You’re going to die.”

The Drake’s smile vanished. He stared at Halrac, as if expecting the [Scout] to smile. But Halrac’s face didn’t change. He folded his arms.

The Drake looked around the table, hoping perhaps for a second opinion. He got none. Revi raised an eyebrow and Ulrien shook his head. Both Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers stared silently at the adventurers. They lost their bravado. In the silence, the leader turned.

“Let’s—let’s go.”

They left the inn quietly. Halrac wished they had stayed, or that they turned towards Liscor, rather than north, towards the second dungeon entrance. He had a feeling he would not see their faces again.

“Our turn.”

Halrac stood up in the silent inn. He nodded towards the door and the Gold-rank adventurers went with them. They walked west out of the inn, towards Liscor and the small, fortified tunnel leading downwards. They were going to the dungeon too. The only difference was that they were ready for it.

Typhenous caught the silent group of Gold-rank adventurers as they were halfway towards the unearthed entrance to Liscor’s dungeon. The [Mage] had been in the city finishing an errand, but they had agreed to meet at this time.

“Why the dour expressions? Has Halrac been talking to all of you too long?”

The [Mage] was in good spirits, but he sobered slightly when he heard about the adventurers trying the dungeon. Typhenous sighed and stroked at his grey beard.

“I had heard of other adventurers attempting to emulate Vuliel Drae’s success. How distressing.”

“They might make it.”

Jelaqua offered the idea up as an idle hope, but Halrac shook his head.

“Too many adventurers. A smaller group might have a chance, but a large one like that generates too much noise and attention. They’ll be attacked at once. Best case is that some of them make it back up.”

“Up a set of ropes that stretches over a hundred feet down? They’ll be lucky if they don’t lose a few just falling, with all that they were carrying. Unless one of them knows [Featherfall].”

“The issue is that their way out is too dangerous. And they’re entering into the middle of the dungeon. If they don’t secure their exit out and make sure they’re not swarmed from behind...”

“Amateurs. This is why you go in from the front. Shortcuts just get you killed.”

Seborn’s sigh was the last word on the matter. Griffon Hunt began to discuss their latest developments as the Halfseekers listened in silence. They trudged through the snow, grilling Typhenous about their latest contingency plan. That was the difference between experienced adventurers and the reckless dead. Gold-rank adventurers *always* made plans.

“I was in the city, requesting a shipment of specialized lodestones. You see, young Pisces had the notion of connecting Miss Solstice’s magical door to more than one location. However, as Moore and I discovered, such a feat is impossible, at least, without proper anchoring points.”

“Makes sense to me.”

Revi nodded while Halrac shook his head.

“Explain it simpler, Typhenous.”

He had no time for [Mage]-talk. Typhenous sighed. He liked to pontificate.

“Very well. We cannot link the door to multiple spots because it is too difficult. Thus, we need magical beacons—ways to differentiate between locations. Thus, the lodestones. Moore had the idea of devising some sort of

mechanism by which the door could be attuned to each stone, creating multiple connections. We shall attempt to change the enchantment when the stones arrive.”

Ulrien nodded, as did Halrac. That they could understand, at least in part. Griffon Hunt’s leader frowned.

“So an emergency teleportation stone like Erin was talking about—”

Typhenous shook his head.

“Impossible until my delivery arrives. It should get here, or rather, to Celum, within the week. I was unwilling to pay a Courier for the stones, given their price and our needs.”

Halrac sighed. The magical artifact Erin had described—an emergency escape device—sounded incredibly useful, although he wasn’t sure if it would work in the dungeon’s magically charged atmosphere. However, it was worth looking into. Such a tool would allow both Gold-rank teams to breathe easier. There was nothing an adventurer feared more than being trapped.

“We don’t need the artifact that badly, but if it looks like we’re heading into a particularly dangerous spot, I’d rather pull back and try to get an emergency escape...lodestone...ready. We have time.”

Ulrien was talking with Typhenous and the others, advocating for caution again. Moore nodded, tapping one huge lip with his fingers.

“If it comes to that, I’m sure Miss Solstice will oblige us. But you don’t think it will be that dangerous today?”

“Not if it’s more of the same. Ah, here we are.”

They’d reached the entrance to the dungeon. The official entrance, so to speak. It was guarded by the city. A group of sixteen guardsmen, armed with bows and spears and one who looked like a [Mage] were waiting under a tent. They were watching the entrance to the dungeon from behind a small wooden rampart. It had a row of sharpened stakes thrust into the ground in front of the wall and enough space for the [Guardsmen] to loose arrows and jab spears at whatever might come out of the dungeon.

“Hello there! We’d like to enter the dungeon!”

Typhenous called up to the [Guardsmen] huddled beneath the tent. Some were sipping hot drinks and they all looked miserable in the cold. One of the Drakes twitched his tail.

“You lot again? The uh...Griffon Hunt team and Halfseekers? Alright, go on through.”

“Is there anyone else down there?”

Ulrien looked at the dungeon for tracks, but the [Guardsmen] shook his head.

“Not today. All you adventurers are too interested in the rift. Suits us. The less of you that go down, the fewer things that come back up. But if you want to go in...be our guests.”

Ulrien nodded. Jelaqua was already hopping over the edge of the ramparts—the Drakes had neglected to build a gate into the defensive fortifications—and Moore was eying the drop.

“I would like to avoid the spikes and squashing you, Jelaqua. Give me more room.”

As Halrac walked up the rampart, he watched Moore jump, and then offer a hand to Revi and Typhenous. The two other [Mages] let the half-Giant guide their descent, rather than fall. Ulrien leapt, and the Drake [Guardsmen] spoke to Halrac. He nodded to the tunnel the Antinium had dug, that lead down to the double doors that marked the start of the dungeon.

“I’ve seen adventuring groups go in and come out. More go in than come out, obviously. But your group’s Gold-rank, right? You go in and come out almost every day? What are you doing down there?”

Halrac grunted.

“Being cautious.”

He leapt, and the Drake [Guardman] rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, I got that. Lousy Humans...”

He turned away, muttering, as Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers descended into the dungeon.

This is what the Gold-rank teams did all day. They went into the dungeon after preparing, making plans, checking gear, and arguing. They moved slowly down the first corridor and stopped when they saw the room beyond. Halrac and Seborn, both of whom were taking point to scout for traps, held up hands and the group stopped.

Both Halrac and Seborn scouted the room, taking care not to enter it and only look into it. There didn't seem to be much to see. The room was empty and nondescript. Halrac saw the wide, grey tiles of stone continue seamlessly into the room. The walls were some kind of faded beige, made of simple stone. Any unsuspecting individual might have taken the room as harmless, but Halrac wasn't fooled. Beyond the first corridor was where the dungeon's traps began. This first room was certainly trapped.

Seborn nodded to the empty room beyond. He'd found a red mark on the wall, a stripe of very bright paint.

"Looks like the same room as before. We've cleared this one."

"You have? I'm not familiar with it."

Halrac had seen many of the dungeon's trapped rooms. They appeared each time you went down the corridor, and what was worse, changed each time you entered the dungeon. There were any number of rooms you could enter, and so you had to be extremely careful not to assume one room was like a previous one.

However, the Gold-rank adventurers were familiar with dungeons and knew how to take precautions. Seborn nodded to the paint, which was a horizontal slash with a vertical line to the left.

"This one's a spike trap. Simple, but deadly. I'll trigger it. You stay back."

He walked into the center of the room and slowed. Seborn took two steps as the other adventurers watched—then threw himself to the ground.

The ceiling fell. A series of phantasmal spikes, glowing ghostly pink-white, shot down through the suddenly low ceiling, almost brushing the top of Seborn's head. Halrac heard Revi inhale as the magical blades shimmered in the air.

“Jelaqua.”

Seborn spoke. Halrac moved aside as Jelaqua stepped forwards. The Selphid was holding her two-handed flail. She threw it out across the floor and Seborn turned and grasped hold of one of the chains. Jelaqua *pulled* and Seborn shot back across the floor while the spikes waited menacingly a few feet over his head.

Halrac helped the [Rogue] up as Seborn patted himself and rubbed the top of his head. The Drowned Man seemed barely fazed. He nodded at Halrac, one trap expert to another.

“That scared the life out of me the first time it happened. I’m not too happy about it the second time.”

Halrac was impressed by Seborn's courage...and a bit disturbed that he'd chosen to throw himself into danger. He would have found a way to trigger the trap without entering the room, but the Halfseekers were more direct. Revi stared at the blades and the lowered ceiling, looking pale.

“Do the blades last forever? What about the ceiling? Do we have to crawl our way to the next room?”

“Nope. Wait for it—”

Jelaqua was barring anyone from going into the room, for good reason. The ceiling spikes were still lowered when Halrac felt his [Dangersense] tingle and then a *second* set of ghostly blades shot up from the ground. They would have impaled Seborn or anyone else who'd been lucky enough to avoid the ceiling. Typhenous and Ulrien muttered as Revi swore quietly.

The Halfseekers had already seen the trap and just shook their heads. Halrac grimaced at the trap.

“Simple, but deadly. That second layer of spikes is malicious—and probably overkill.”

“The difference between a dungeon designed for vengeance and one that's not?”

Revi looked at the others and got a nod from Seborn and Halrac. Having seen the trap, the adventurers drew back to confer.

“The trap’s got a timer of around one hour before it resets, and the spikes are smaller...the spell probably needs more time to fully recharge. We can keep triggering it each time we go through, but if the aim of all of this is to clear all the rooms going in so we’ve got a way out, we can’t have that trap still here.”

“I agree. Can any of you dispel it?”

Jelaqua and Ulrien were both of the same opinion. Typhenous, Revi, and Moore were all inspecting the spell, but it was apparently hidden in the ceiling. Seborn and Halrac were in their own conference, inspecting the room now the spikes were gone. Both [Scout] and [Rogue] were ready to leap to safety if the trap reactivated, but their Skills were telling them they were safe for the moment.

“I’m of the opinion the trap is magical. It activates the moment I cross this threshold. See?”

Seborn was talking to Halrac. The [Scout] nodded. He could see a faint aura around the part of the room Seborn had described.

“Cross that line and step anywhere in the room and the trap activates. Want to try breaking the floor?”

“Worth a shot. Do you have a hammer?”

“Allow me.”

Ulrien stepped forwards and both Seborn and Halrac retreated. The big [Warrior] took his greatsword out and gripped the blade with both of his gauntleted hands. Using the hilt of his sword like a hammer, he *cracked* the stone floor with a mighty strike.

“Hm. Not spelled against strikes. Will that do it?”

Carefully, Ulrien inspected his greatsword as Halrac and Seborn knelt by the cracked stones. Ulrien’s blade was enchanted, but he obsessed over it. Halrac nodded as he saw no aura around the stones.

“That does it. Let’s tear up the room and see if that deactivates the trap.”

So they did. Moore and Jelaqua and Ulrien began hitting the ground, Moore with his staff, Jelaqua with her flail, and Ulrien with his greatsword. All three could break the stone and Halrac, Seborn, Revi, and Typhenous helped clear the rubble away.

No one used a hammer. A sledgehammer was less useful than an enchanted weapon. You could swing Ulrien's greatsword all day and not chip the blade or hilt, whereas a sledgehammer would eventually break.

It was hard on the hands, though. Twice Ulrien had to take a break and massage his hands. Mordhau, as the technique he was using was known, was not meant for repeated strikes like a hammer.

By the time an hour had passed, half of the room was destroyed and the smooth tiled flooring had been broken away and a rougher surface had been exposed. Seborn once again entered the room and very cautiously walked from side to side, testing to see if the trigger mechanism for the spell had been successfully destroyed.

It had. However, that didn't mean everyone crossed through the room at once. Halrac carefully entered the room and did the same test as Seborn, senses alert for anything suspicious. Only after he was done did he let both teams go through one at a time.

That was the first room. The second was a pit trap nearly thirty feet deep. Halrac showed the Halfseekers where he and the rest of his team had strung up a rope bridge to cross without having to touch the ground. The third room was filled with books on shelves—they were supposed to explode when read. The adventurers walked past them without touching any of the tomes.

The fourth room they came to was unfamiliar to both Seborn and Halrac. It was locked by a door, and after determining the door itself wasn't trapped, Halrac and Seborn carefully opened the door and gazed into a circular room with a grating floor and very dark pit.

"I'm not going in there."

"Me neither. Think the door closes after someone goes in?"

"Obviously. Let's take it off."

Some traps were predictable. Halrac motioned Ulrien over and explained what they wanted to do. Ulrien sighed and grabbed the door's edge. He was incredibly strong—strong enough to swing around his greatsword like it was nothing, and Halrac had seen Ulrien beat a Minotaur in arm-wrestling once. But no matter how hard Ulrien strained, the door wouldn't budge.

“Allow me to help.”

Moore had to duck his head as he grabbed the door with one hand. He and Ulrien pulled at the door and now Halrac heard *creaking* as the door and its hinges fought with the wall of the dungeon to be freed.

“Room for one more?”

Jelaqua handed her flail to Seborn and stepped up, edging between Ulrien and Moore. Between the three strongest adventurers, the door was beginning to come loose. Ulrien grunted.

“Ready? One, two, three, *heave*—”

The three adventurers *pushed*, and with a *crack* of breaking stone, the door broke off its hinges and they let it crash to the ground. Rubbing at their arms, they let Seborn and Halrac inspect the room again.

“Enchanted doors. As if they didn't expect us to pull each one off. Waste of time.”

Halrac grunted. Seborn nodded.

“Waste of time. And I bet the door's not got more than a protection spell on it. Still, it might be worth taking back with us.”

“Why? Who needs a door with a protection spell?”

“Someone might pay some gold for it. You must admit, enchanted doors aren't cheap. If worst comes to worst, some Bronze-rank adventurer can use it as a shield.”

The dry comment made Halrac grin unwillingly. He got along with Seborn, which wasn't surprising as both occupied the same role in their party. Seborn nodded at the center of the room.

“Ah, I see. It's a pressure mechanism.”

“You think so?”

Halrac was surprised. He hadn't seen any magical aura that would have indicated a detection spell, but he hadn't noticed the way the grate was wired to a spring until Seborn pointed out the tiny grooves where the grating would descend to trigger the trap. Halrac shook his head, grateful for a second pair of eyes.

“Simple trigger. Typhenous, I need a ball of webbing. Heavy. Unless Revi wants to use one of her summoned creatures as a test?”

“Spare me.”

Revi rolled her eyes as Typhenous spun out some sticky webs from his staff. The enchanted webbing would only last a few minutes, but it was a useful tool and one of the reasons why he was in Griffon Hunt.

“Mind if I add something to it? I can conjure grass, or grass clippings. If it's weight you're after, that might help.”

“By all means, Moore.”

The half-Giant tapped his staff and some magical grass and vines grew out of the stone. He carefully mixed that with the webbing and came up with a heavy ball of plant matter and webs. Halrac and Seborn rolled it to the door as they talked conversationally.

“I haven't had time to see Revi fight. She's your second [Mage], right?”

“[Summoner], actually. She can conjure spirits of Stitch-warriors or summon other creatures. It's useful, but not when we're disarming traps. Her summoned creatures can't think for themselves.”

“Ah. Here we go. Would you like to do the honors?”

“Sure.”

Halrac kicked the ball of heavy matter into the room. He saw the grating descend fractionally, and then both he and Seborn leapt backwards.

“So that's the trap.”

“Yep. Acid mist.”

Halrac and Seborn backed up into the previous room as all the Gold-rank adventurers drew back. A very fine spray of colorless liquid was shooting down from above. It didn't affect the stone or metal, but the instant it struck the plants and webbing, the ball began smoking and disintegrating with a subtle hiss.

Jelaqua shook her head as the others waited for the trap to finish its work. As a warrior, she and Ulrien were of the least use in this situation. She leaned against a wall with Ulrien, ready to help if called upon, but mostly alert for a monster sneaking up around them. Since they were fairly confident no monsters existed in the trapped rooms they'd passed through, she allowed herself a short conversation.

"How many more rooms are like this, do you think?"

Ulrien shrugged his broad shoulders as he watched the acid make the stone walls slick with moisture.

"Impossible to say. But there has to be a limited number. Once we're through here, we can be sure our exit's safe. Unless there's a teleportation trap hidden on the way back?"

He looked at the other [Mages], all of whom shook their heads. Typhenous tapped the walls with his staff.

"I have been checking for that diligently, as per your orders, Ulrien."

"As have I."

Moore nodded. Reassured, Ulrien looked at Revi. She shrugged, looking embarrassed and annoyed.

"Not my specialty! I told you that Ulrien! But I haven't seen anything either."

He nodded. The adventurers sat back when it became apparent the acid wasn't stopping anytime soon. They began to chatter idly while they waited. Other, less-experienced groups might have stayed on their feet or tried to find something to do, but the Gold-rank teams knew patience was their biggest asset.

"Acid mist. Great. Didn't Erin say she used to sell acid?"

"Sell acid? You must have heard her wrong."

“I’d believe anything of her. Want to try and bottle it up?”

“It’s magical acid. It’ll disappear after a few minutes.”

“Ah.”

“I hate traps like these. What’s the point? A few seconds of acid and you’re dead. Why waste spell power keeping it going?”

“I guess in case someone casts a spell. The acid probably wears away at magical protections too. If you’ve got an enchanted cloak for instance, this is probably when the acid eats away.”

“Nasty. Hey, anyone want some food?”

“You brought a *snack*? What’s the point? We’re five seconds away from Liscor.”

“I get munchy when I’m bored, and this is boring. Toasted baguette anyone? I’ll share. Ham and cheese. Erin made it for me.”

“I’ll have some.”

“Well, if you’re offering...”

Jelaqua split her sandwich with Typhenous and Seborn. As they ate, Ulrien looked over at his counterpart. Jelaqua’s white face was pale as death, and she was unmistakably a corpse, but there was still life behind the eyes. Literally.

“You lot are very relaxed, especially in the middle of a dungeon.”

She grinned at him, chewing and swallowing her meal. Part of Halrac wondered whether Jelaqua could taste the food she ate—then he remembered her complaining about trying to keep her body’s taste buds fresh so she could enjoy food.

“Shouldn’t we be? What’s the use of tensing up?”

“We like tense. And serious. Halrac and I are both former soldiers—and we hunt Griffins. Idle chatter in the field can alert our quarry and get us all killed.”

“Right, that’s in the name of your group. I wish we were so efficient.”

“No you don’t. You’d quit if you couldn’t talk every two seconds.”

Moore nudged Jelaqua with one finger. She grinned and swatted at him.

“Okay, I wish *I* was that efficient.”

“Each to their own. It’s not like the Halfseekers don’t get the job done.”

“True. Hey, was that a compliment? From Halrac the Grim no less. Hah!”

Jelaqua laughed and Halrac scowled. She waved at him.

“Don’t take it so personally. I’m happy to hear that, really. And I wish I had a title. All I get called is ‘corpse snatcher’ and ‘body thief’, and all Selphids get called that.”

“I didn’t ask for my title. *Ulrien* doesn’t have a nickname. There’s no reason for me to have one if you don’t.”

Halrac snapped and rose. The acid had stopped, although the walls were still wet. He went to study the room with Seborn while Jelaqua turned to Ulrien. The Selphid looked concerned.

“I didn’t mean to offend him.”

Ulrien grimaced, looking at his friend’s back.

“Don’t take it personally. Halrac just doesn’t like the attention. It’s nothing to do with you.”

“Yeah, well, you know how titles go. We don’t choose them, other people do. And you have to admit, it suits him.”

Jelaqua winked slyly at Halrac, whose shoulders had tensed up. Ulrien smiled and covered it with a hand.

“He has a point, though. Halrac’s one of the best [Scouts] on the continent, and probably one of the best ones working as an adventurer, but he’s hardly as noticeable as your team is. Come to that, the Halfseekers have more of a reputation in the south than Griffon Hunt does.”

“Aw. Stop. You’re making me blush. See my orange cheeks?”

Tickled, Jelaqua laughed and pointed to her cheeks, which were indeed glowing slightly orange. Ulrien smiled and Typhenous leaned forwards, chewing aggressively while crumbs fell into his beard.

“Ulrien does have a point, though. I’m quite old, but the Halfseekers have been around for a long time, haven’t they, Miss Ivirith? I wouldn’t be surprised if you were older than I was. When I was young, I remember hearing you’d come from Baleros as a Silver-rank adventurer. I recall a time when the Halfseekers were one of the best Gold-rank teams on the continent. There were seven of you back then, weren’t there?”

Jelaqua stopped laughing. She lost her smile, and Ulrien saw Moore sit up slightly. The two Halfseekers looked at each other wordlessly. Typhenous coughed.

“Forgive me if I misspoke. I did not mean to pry.”

Adventurer deaths were common, but each party remembered their own differently. Halrac and Ulrien had buried more than a few friends, and it was courtesy not to bring up the fallen. But Jelaqua shook her head. She put her hands on her knees and sat cross-legged as Moore rested his weight on his staff, looking tired.

“Eight. There were eight of us, not too long ago. We were great, yeah. We thought we could become a Named Adventuring team. None of us were on that level of course, but together? We could have taken down a nest of adult Crelers and fought our way through a trio of Wyverns like that.”

She snapped her fingers softly. Halrac and Seborn half-turned—they were trying to saw through parts of the grate. Jelaqua waved a hand and they turned away.

The other adventurers sat a bit closer. Revi scooted over, looking concerned.

“What happened then? If you don’t mind telling. I remember hearing the Halfseekers had lost a lot of their group, but I never heard what happened.”

Typhenous cleared his throat gently.

“I ah, heard it was in relation to the Sepicus Delve, where you fought through the caverns and looted the swallowed treasures...?”

“Close, but not quite.”

Jelaqua grinned and then shook her head, closing her eyes and frowning sadly. Moore’s head was lowered.

“It was actually after that. We got chewed up down there, but we came back, all eight of us. I was wounded and needed a new body, Moore was too hurt to walk and needed the poisons leached out of him before he could be healed and Seborn was asleep when it happened. Our other five members were checking over our loot when a fight broke out.”

“Over treasure? But that’s such a rookie…”

Revi broke off at Ulrien’s glance. Fighting over magical artifacts was a typical end to many groups, but he had a feeling that wasn’t what Jelaqua was referring to.

He was right. Jelaqua shook her head.

“If it was a quarrel over treasure…no. This was different. It was betrayal, pure and simple. One of our own turned on us. He slaughtered four of our own and fled with everything we’d found. We went after him of course, but we never found him. Moore, Seborn and I are all that’s left.”

Silence fell after Jelaqua’s story. Ulrien stared at the Selphid.

“That is odd. Fighting over an artifact is one thing, but killing? Was what you recovered so valuable?”

“No! And that’s the damned thing!”

She struck her leg repeatedly, bruising her dead flesh until Moore grabbed her hand. He spoke while Jelaqua looked down.

“I am afraid the matter isn’t so cut and dried, Ulrien. If it were just treasure our companion wanted…we might have given him all of it. We don’t discriminate if the needs of one of our group outweighs the other. But instead, our friend—”

“That bastard.”

Jelaqua muttered. Moore nodded.

“He ran with everything and killed our companions. Not because he feared we’d make him share, but, we think, to hide what was stolen.”

“An artifact of great power?”

Typhenous sat up, eyes alert. Moore nodded quietly.

“Or a secret.”

“And he’s still at large? Your companion? Who is he?”

Ulrien looked at Jelaqua. It seemed incredible that a Gold-rank adventurer could turn traitor and he not hear of it. Normally every adventurer within a thousand miles would receive a bounty on the head of the criminal. The Adventurer’s Guild did not tolerate traitors. But Jelaqua and Moore paused.

“He’s alive, but there’s no bounty on him and no one knows he’s out there but us. We couldn’t tell anyone else except for our closest allies, and we had few of those even in the good days.”

“You can count us among them. If not to help, at least to listen.”

Ulrien spoke for his group. Jelaqua hesitated. She looked at Moore and he nodded. She sighed.

“Okay, but you’ll understand why we kept this secret. You know the Halfseekers are all about taking races that don’t quite fit? Not just half races like half-Elves or half-Giants like Moore...people like me. Selphids. Races that don’t quite fit with other groups. Well, our last member was really different. He was a Goblin.”

Revi gasped. There was a *clang*, and then an oath. Halrac, working in the room next door, had dropped his metal file in surprise. Of course he’d been listening as well. Ulrien stared at Jelaqua.

“No. A Goblin? How could that be possible? They’re savages.”

She shrugged tiredly.

“Looks like they are in the end. But our companion was a Hobgoblin, not an ordinary one, you know? He was as good as any Goblin Chieftain—better, actually. We always thought he was as good as a Goblin could get without being a Goblin Lord. His name was...Garen Redfang. We know he’s still alive. Got his own tribe now too, by the sounds of it.”

“Redfang. Redfang...I’ve heard of that tribe. It’s one of the Goblin tribes around the High Passes. It’s considered a danger to Gold-rank adventurers.”

Ulrien recalled the warnings. There were only a few Goblin tribes with that kind of warning, and the Redfang tribe had earned theirs by killing

several Silver and Gold-rank teams that had gone after them. Jelaqua grimaced.

“That’s not surprising. Garen was...one of our best warriors. A natural leader, too. He’s a [Rider] and a [Warrior] and he’s got magical artifacts. Like any Gold-rank adventurer.”

“So he betrayed your team. Over what?”

“We don’t know!”

The Selphid spread her arms helplessly. She looked around at the others.

“We were wary of Garen, but he was with us for *two years* and saved all of our lives more than once. He was one of us, but when he found the treasure...I knew there was something wrong. But I can’t remember what we pulled out. I was almost dead and one of my eyes was missing—”

“Seborn remembers a key, a magical orb of some kind, some spell scrolls, a few magical weapons...it may be the key, but what would a Goblin know of keys? Their people don’t use keys and identifying the lock would be a tremendous task for the most well-informed [Spymaster]. If the key even had a lock. As for the rest...”

Moore shook his huge head. Ulrien and the others sat in silence for a while. In the distance, they heard Halrac and Seborn finally cut through the grating and send the entire contraption *clanging* into the pit below.

“If your companion’s a threat, he needs to be taken care of. Justice should be done for your fallen. After this dungeon...we could discuss it.”

Ulrien offered the suggestion to Jelaqua. She nodded tiredly. A bit of a smile crept back onto her face, which Ulrien was glad to see.

“Who knew Griffon Hunt was full of such softies? Don’t let it get out or Halrac’s reputation will be ruined. And don’t worry—we won’t let the past get in the way of the dungeon. To rebuild our group we need coin and treasure, and that’s what we’re here for.”

“But you won’t forget, will you?”

Revi spoke up. Ulrien looked at her and saw the Stitch Girl’s hands were clenched. The String People valued their own highly, he recalled. No

wonder Revi felt passionate. Jelaqua nodded slowly and Moore sat up. The gentle half-Giant's eyes were shadowed.

"Don't worry, we won't forget. Ever. Garen knows it, which is why he's always kept his head down. He's on our list."

With that, the conversation ended. Seborn and Halrac came back to report the trapped room had been cleared and they were constructing a bridge across the chasm to the next room. The Gold-ranked adventurers moved onto the next trapped room, and the next.

Six hours after they'd begun, the Halfseekers and Griffon Hunt emerged blinking back into the white, snowy world. They were covered in dirt, tired, hungry despite Jelaqua's snack, and on-edge from dealing with traps and close calls.

One of the last traps had extended back into the corridor and one of the camouflaged wall scorpions had nearly stabbed Ulrien through the face. It had got Revi in the arm, but she'd pulled her arm off and had cut the envenomed cotton away. She still needed a healing potion though, and the pain from reattaching her arm and feeling the wound in her flesh for a few moments had made her more snappish than usual.

"Hold! Who goes there?"

"Us! It's always us!"

Jelaqua shouted as the [Guardsmen] on the barricades heard them coming up the tunnel. After a pause they were allowed to continue, and the Gold-rank adventurers found a flurry of commotion on the wall. One of the Gnolls tossed down a ladder so the adventurers could climb up. The rest were packing up their gear and heading towards the city.

"What's going on?"

Ulrien and the other adventurers were immediately alert. The Gnoll paused long enough to growl at them.

"Trouble. Something just crawled out of the second dungeon entrance! The Captain's locking down the gates! If you want into the city, hurry!"

He loped off towards the gates. The adventurers looked at each other. Typhenous frowned.

“Up through the chasm? But that rift stretches down hundreds of feet —”

“Not a problem for some monsters, especially if they can fly. What should we do? I can scout the trouble.”

Halrac was looking at Ulrien. The big man considered their options. As Gold-rank adventurers they were expected to help in times of crisis, but that didn’t mean taking on every threat, especially when a city like Liscor could easily defend its walls from most enemies.

Revi shook her head as the Gold-rank adventurers conferred.

“It’s not our fight. Why invite trouble?”

“Erin’s inn isn’t within city limits. That’s all the trouble you need, especially if whatever’s out there decides they want an easier snack.”

Jelaqua pointed that out and Ulrien nodded. He turned to Halrac.

“Halrac—”

“I’m gone.”

The [Scout] charged through the snow, running fast despite the deep drifts as he scouted ahead. His Skills would let him see danger and avoid it which is why Ulrien let him go alone. Jelaqua was looking at Seborn.

“I could let Seborn—”

“Not necessary. Halrac’s a [Scout]. He can retreat if anything comes at him. Unless Seborn has similar Skills?”

“Point. Let’s get to Erin’s inn, then!”

The Gold-rank adventurers began marching hard through the snow, keeping an eye out for trouble. On the walls of Liscor, they saw Drakes and Gnolls running back and forth. The gates closed as a group of people streamed through it. The Gold-rank adventurers marched on, yet the monsters weren’t visible from their position on the snowy plains.

“There’s Halrac!”

Revi shouted as she saw the [Scout] racing towards them over a hill. Halrac waved his hand and pointed north—both teams of adventurers picked up the pace and met him halfway.

“Undead! Two Flesh Worms, two Crypt *Lords*—a score of Ghouls and lesser undead as well.”

“From that hole in the ground? How?”

Jelaqua demanded as Halrac took a few deep breaths. The [Scout] grimaced.

“It looks like they crawled *up* the hole somehow. They probably used the ropes those idiots left! I think the Flesh Worms carried both Crypt Lords. And the undead—I’m fairly certain they’re the group that left.”

“Damn it.”

Ulrien wasn’t one to curse often. He frowned as he looked towards the Wandering Inn in the distance. It was near Liscor, and it wasn’t a stretch to think the undead might target it.

“Didn’t Liscor have a big problem with a Flesh Worm one time? A special one?”

“Skinner. I’ve heard the stories. It got over the wall. Want to bet these ones can do the same?”

“No bets. I’m of the mind that we take the undead out rather than risk them attacking the inn or the city. If they killed that adventuring group, we can avenge them. It’s the right thing to do. What does your group think?”

Ulrien looked at Jelaqua. She grinned.

“We’re down for a fight. You leave one of the Flesh Worms to us—we’ll hit them from one side and you squeeze them from the other. That sound good?”

“Works for us.”

There was no time to come up with a detailed plan and besides, both teams didn’t need anything elaborate. The enemy wasn’t that dangerous. Ulrien gave rapid orders to his group, going over a plan of attack while they marched through the snow towards the rift.

“I want our worm immobilized. Revi can deal with the bulk of the lesser undead, and Halrac can support from the air.”

“You want him high up?”

Typhenous looked at Ulrien. Both Halrac and Ulrien nodded.

“There’s no ranged or aerial threats, aside from the Crypt Lords spitting black blood. You and Revi keep back while I engage the Crypt Lord. Just pour on spells from the side and we’ll be fine.”

“Got it.”

Both [Mages] nodded. Ulrien grunted, drew his greatsword, and picked up the pace. Within minutes he could see shapes rushing over the snow in the distance. Two giant red worms, writhing and shooting across the landscape at unsettling speed were leading a pair of giant Crypt Lords, amalgamations of rotten flesh and bone. A horde of zombies, ghouls, and skeletons rushed behind them. It was an army of the undead, but Ulrien knew the only true threats were the Flesh Worms.

They were both twenty feet long, had thick red flesh, tiny black eyes and long antennae, and two whip-like appendages with feelers on the ends. These feelers could latch onto flesh and tear it away in an instant. Ulrien had heard stories of Flesh Worms building themselves obscene layers of armor from the skin of their victims over time. These ones didn’t have any such protections, but they were fast, strong, and capable of wiping out a party of Bronze or Silver-rank adventurers by themselves.

Not Gold-rank, though. Not Griffon Hunt. The instant the undead were spotted, Ulrien stopped and lifted his greatsword up, blade flat. Halrac ran towards him, bow at the ready and Typhenous raised his staff.

It was a maneuver they’d performed many times. Halrac leapt onto the flat of Ulrien’s huge blade and Ulrien grunted. He heaved *up*, and Halrac leapt from his sword into the air as Typhenous raised his staff.

“[Platform of Air].”

Halrac landed on the transparent disc ten feet above the ground and reached for the quiver at his side. He snapped down at the others as he put an arrow with a shimmering yellow-tipped head to his bowstring.

“Shocking left!”

“Immobilizing right. [Sticky Webbing].”

Typhenous lifted his staff as Halrac shot the first arrow. There was over twenty meters separating him and the Flesh Worm, but his arrow still stuck

the undulating red serpent straight between the eyes. It *shrieked*, making Halrac clench his teeth as lightning burst from his arrow and made the Flesh Worm twist upon itself in agony.

At the same time, a stream of grey tendrils lashed out from Typhenous' staff. The older [Mage] caught the second Flesh Worm with the mass as it tried to evade. The sticky web from his spell anchored parts of the worm to the ground, impeding its movement. The Flesh Worm tore up parts of the ground as it tried to free itself.

"Whoo! Mage support! Alright Halfseekers, let's do this!"

Jelaqua's team was less refined than Griffon Hunt. They charged across the snow at the first Flesh Worm, all three of them. It twisted upright, hissing, as Jelaqua whirled her flail and attacked its side.

Ulrien charged the second Flesh Worm as it struggled to free itself. The snow was making his footing unstable, so he took care to plant himself in front of the worm before slashing. The worm swung a feeler at his head and Ulrien *cut*. The Flesh Worm screamed as one of its 'arms' was severed and fell to the ground. Ulrien pressed the attack, cutting into its side with his greatsword.

"I will assist Ulrien. Revi, the Crypt Lord is advancing."

Typhenous commented to Revi as he shot magical missiles of light at the Flesh Worm's head, forcing it to dodge as Ulrien sliced into its side, trying to saw it in half. Revi sighed.

"I see it old man. Give me one second."

She reached into her pouch and pulled out a huge chunk of amber. Embedded in the center was a fragment, a bit of horn. Revi held it up and shouted.

"Come forth! Rush, Corusdeer!"

As the Crypt Lord advanced, spitting black blood onto the ground, something shimmered in the air in front of Revi. A bright, antlered shape burst out of the air and the fire from its body melted the earth. Revi pointed and uttered a command.

A glowing Corusdeer formed out of red and yellow fire charged towards the first Crypt Lord. It rammed the undead and there was a wordless howl

as it engulfed the Crypt Lord in flames. The Corusdeer broke off, ran a circle in the snow, and rammed the Crypt Lord from the other side. Revi was pointing, commanding its path as two spectral warriors appeared in front of her and Typhenous, waiting for the Ghouls to approach.

Halrac drew an arrow to his cheek and loosed it at a Ghoul. The arrow hit the undead in the head as it ran and the Ghoul dropped. Halrac turned, shot a Ghoul trying to sneak up on the [Mages] from behind, and looked over at the Halfseekers to see how they were doing.

Jelaqua was a whirling image of death as befit her [Iron Tempest] class. Her two-handed flail was a danger to everything around her, and the undead charging at her were torn to bits by her whirling flail's heads. She closed on the Flesh Worm as it hissed at her. It lashed out, but one of Jelaqua's flails smacked its tail away as it tried to hit the Selphid.

"I will take it down."

Moore ran towards the Flesh Worm, long legs churning through the snow. The half-Giant raised his staff and balled his other hand into a fist.

"[Thorny Fist]."

Thick brambles of dark wood engulfed his right hand. Huge thorns shot out, dark and grey like iron and turned Moore's hand into a deadly weapon. He lashed out at the Flesh Worm—

And missed. The giant red worm was incredibly agile. It leaned back and dove head-first at Moore, mouth opened wide. He blocked it with his enchanted hand, but the magical gauntlet of wood and thorns wasn't stronger than the Flesh Worm's flesh. It had bitten through several layers of the bark surrounding his vulnerable skin when Seborn appeared and stabbed the Flesh Worm in the side with glowing daggers.

It screamed as part of its flesh caught on fire and whirled to attack Seborn. The [Rogue] dove out of the way and seemed to vanish in the snow. Moore backed up, shaking his hand.

"Thanks, Seborn."

"Take care of the undead. Let Jelaqua and I handle the worm."

"Agreed."

Moore took a few steps back as Jelaqua lashed the Flesh Worm's side with her flail and Seborn stabbed its tail. He turned and saw the undead were about to fall on his party from behind.

The half-Giant calmly kicked a zombie hard enough to send it flying through the air, punched a Ghoul down as it leapt on him, and then stepped on its back. Halrac winced as he heard bones *crack*.

The other Crypt Lord charged Moore, but hesitantly. It was actually shorter than the half-Giant and Moore was nearly as wide as it was. Moore used the remains of his enchanted hand to hold the Crypt Lord at bay as its rows of teeth and claws scratched harmlessly at his wooden gauntlet. Then he raised his staff with his left hand.

Moore thrust the tip of his broad staff *into* the Crypt Lord's side, tearing into dead flesh and pushing the undead monstrosity back. As it tried to swipe at him, Moore uttered a spell.

“[Entangling Vines].”

Thick, green ropes of plant matter erupted from the Crypt Lord's side. It engulfed the struggling undead as Moore let go, sealing its mouth, anchoring it to the ground and rendering it immobile. Moore nodded.

“Problem solved.”

The half-Giant turned away and began hitting the undead around him with his staff, not bothering with more spells. In the meantime, Jelaqua had brought the battle to the Flesh Worm.

Five times, ten times, twenty times she struck the Flesh Worm's side with her flail. Its hide was incredibly thick, but the force of each of her flail strikes was able to tear into its hide slightly. And she kept *hitting* it. Jelaqua's arms were a blur as she lashed the Flesh Worm's side, tearing it apart hit by hit. She was laughing as she attacked.

“*Strikestrikestrikestrikestrike*—whoa, that was close.”

Jelaqua ducked low as the Flesh Worm lashed out towards her with its feelers. It swung its body around and its tail came at waist height. Jelaqua cursed as she dove beneath it, and then saw the Flesh Worm poised to lunge. The worm opened its mouth and then an arrow sprouted from one eye.

It screamed. Seborn took the opportunity to sever a good section of its lower body with a decisive strike. The Flesh Worm screamed again as it bled orange-red blood and tried to retreat. Jelaqua cut it off and her flail caught it on the head this time.

“Take this!”

She lifted her flail and buried the spiked ball into the Flesh Worm’s head. The worm screamed, tried to move. Jelaqua whirled her flail, building up speed. She hit the same place again. And then again. The third blow crunched something in the Flesh Worm’s brains and it went still.

As the gigantic creatures stopped moving, Jelaqua studied the broken arrow shaft in its eye and looked around. She saw Halrac standing on his platform of air, shooting down Ghouls and Zombies. She waved a hand at him as he turned his head her way and grinned.

Halrac lifted one hand. He grinned as he shot a Ghoul through the head. Jelaqua laughed and spun. Her flail crushed a zombie’s skull and she whirled her two-handed flail, knocking another zombie off of its feet.

Ulrien finally managed to hack the second Flesh Worm in half and dashed back as it fell to the ground, screaming. It was still alive though, and Typhenous had to blast it with [Fireballs] twice before it fell. Revi’s summoned Corusdeer had incinerated her Crypt Lord, and with her summoned warriors and Halrac’s shooting, the rest of the undead on their side were cleaned up in minutes.

All the undead around Moore had been thoroughly smashed as well. The half-Giant was leaning on his staff and talking to Seborn as he regarded the bound Crypt Lord. No one was in the mood for a fair fight, so Revi let her Corusdeer charge into the Crypt Lord and burn it to pieces. The adventurers headed back towards the Wandering Inn, chatting and cleaning undead gore off of their weapons.

There was something cathartic about fighting monsters. It was simple. There was no tension, worrying that a trap might go off and endanger the group. When you killed a monster, you killed it for good, even if that meant burning the remains until there was nothing left.

“Nice moves against the Flesh Worm. Have you fought them before?”

Ulrien was chatting with Jelaqua. She shook her head, looking rueful.

“No. I didn’t expect the bugger to be so *quick*! Your Halrac’s a great shot, though. I’d prefer not tangling with those worms anyways, to be honest. My flail’s not a good matchup against them.”

“True. Holding them down and cutting them apart works for my group.”

“Oh? Well next time I think we’ll just let Moore entangle it and then beat it to death as well. He’s got some great vine spells, as you saw back there.”

Revi was smiling for once, and chatting with Seborn and Moore.

“Think we’ll get a bounty on the undead?”

“Perhaps. Although we didn’t take any trophies.”

“Trophies? You can see their bodies over there! If the city wants proof so bad, they can just come out here and count themselves. Anyways, that was refreshing. Anyone want a drink?”

Moore nodded.

“I could do with a keg of something spicy. And Lyonette promised me a lot of pasta with meatballs tonight. I prefer the Gnollish kind, having tried them.”

“Ooh, share some with me. I think I’ll have Erin make this... ‘lasagna’ she keeps talking about tonight.”

“I’m partial to that as well. Let’s order some for all of us.”

The Gold-rank adventurers returned to the inn, chatting, smiling, and not talking about the adventurers that had died. It was part of their life. The others had taken a risk and paid for it. Mourning them was appropriate, and perhaps some words would be said. But death was too often part of their lives for it to detract from living.

“Hey! It’s you guys! How are you? Had a busy day?”

Erin Solstice looked up from her tables, beaming as the Gold-rank adventurers took a seat. In moments she had drinks coming their way courtesy of Drassi, and she was already directing Lyonette to take out the pre-cooked lasagna, much to Revi’s delight and Seborn’s dismay.

“I’m not a fan of cheese. Cows are...odd creatures. We don’t have things like them in the sea. Do you have anything less cheese related?”

“How about fish? Lyonette had one jump out at her and she beat it to death with a bucket. Sound good?”

“That would be excellent. Can you make it spicy?”

“Will do! Oh, by the way, did Lyonette tell you all about what I wanted to talk to you earlier about but never got the chance to talk about?”

Halrac blinked and Typhenous rubbed his ears as the adventurers tried to decode Erin’s convoluted statement. Moore sat up as Lyonette and Drassi lifted a huge pot of spaghetti and meatballs onto his table.

“I recall something about slimes.”

“Yeah! Slimes! Let me get your food and we’ll talk. Or actually, Lyonette and the others will get your food and I’ll talk. Isn’t having help great?”

Erin beamed as she hovered around the tables with her guests. She had hot food, cool drinks, and a warm, inviting smile. All an adventurer wanted at the end of the day. Well, Revi could have done without the smile. She just wanted the drinks.

“How was your day? Did anything interesting happen? I heard there was some kind of monster attack, but Bird says all the monsters are ‘taken care of’. Did anything crazy happen to you guys?”

Halrac glanced over at the rest of his team, and then at Jelaqua and the Halfseekers. It was the Selphid who grinned and casually took a mug from Lyonette’s tray.

“Oh, nothing special. What’s this about slimes?”

So it went. Adventurers did their jobs and got paid for it. Some were quiet heroes, others bold and unapologetic. The experienced ones took

calculated risks and paved the way for others to follow. They did their job, and it was a mark of experience that they did not brag about what they did.

However, the inexperienced didn't know that and so talked constantly. On one snowy trail recently cleared by flame magic, one such adventurer was lauding his achievements to a very patient, very blind young man on a wagon. Laken Godart sat on the wagon's back, wishing for once that he were blind and deaf.

“—so as I said, we're not *Gold-rank* adventurers, but we're...pretty close. I mean, Silver-rank's the best you'll see around most parts. Not Invisil, true, but I like to think we're competitive with Gold-rank teams for a lot of assignments.”

One of the adventurers, a young man with a sword and an air of unwarranted confidence, was riding a horse and chattering to Laken. He was quite taken with the [Emperor], mainly because Laken was rumored to be some sort of rich [Lord] and it never hurt to impress the nobility. He was the leader of the Windfrozen Riders, one of the two Silver-rank teams Laken had hired to protect Riverfarm and escort him back to his village.

He was regretting that choice. Charitable though the Windfrozen Riders might be to the plight of simple villagers, humble they were not. Their leader had talked his ear off for three hours straight, and this was the second day of travelling with him. He only broke off when Durene walked to the head of the wagon and spoke with Laken.

“Laken.”

“Oh, Durene. Thank you for saving my ears. Is he gone?”

“He's talking to Gamel. Hey, Laken, can I punch him?”

“What? Durene...no. No, that wouldn't be right.”

It was uncharacteristic of the half-Troll to be violent at all. However, she was almost as annoyed with the cocky adventurer as Laken was. He dismissed her question, trying not to imagine how satisfying the sound of her thumping the young adventurer would be.

“Patience, Durene. We need these adventurers as friends. I'll ask him to quiet down a bit, but violence isn't the answer. Punching him wouldn't do him any good, would it?”

Durene made a disgruntled sound.

“No, but if I punch him, I’ll save him from being killed by the other adventurers. The [Mage] with the glasses say she’ll turn him into a toad. Can she do that?”

Laken laughed, and then frowned thoughtfully.

“She’s a [Witch]. And I think she’s not high enough level to do that. She’d probably only give him a long tongue and slimy skin. Maybe some webbed feet, but that’s all.”

He heard a shuffle, and then a note of complaint in Durene’s voice.

“Okay, but can I punch him anyways? He keeps telling me that he’s got a second sword just as long as his first sword. Which is impossible. It wouldn’t fit in his pants. And who’d want a sword that big, anyways?”

Laken made an amused face.

“You’d be surprised what some guys think they’d like, Durene.”

There was a pause. Durene trudged alongside the wagon as Laken found Frostwing’s head. The bird was getting very big, and she was starting to flap her wings as if she was trying to fly. Laken wondered what would happen when she did. Would he be able to command Frostwing? Talk to her? He was a [Beast Tamer].

After a moment, Durene edged closer and whispered in Laken’s ear.

“You know I don’t mean sword, right? He was talking about his pe—”

“I get it, Durene.”

“So can I hit him?”

Laken sighed. He could hear the adventurer coming back towards the wagon. He stared ahead, and wished he were back at Riverfarm sooner.

“Well?”

“I’m thinking about it.”

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There's a feeling I've had once before. That of standing on the edge of a cliff.

It's a different sensation than you'd expect for someone who's blind. Because, obviously, any time I stand on a ledge higher than three feet, I can't tell how far the ground below is. I'll feel the missing space with my walking cane and back away.

But a cliff? A cliff is different. I have to know it's there for it to be really special. As it happened, I was standing on a ledge on the side of a mountain and when I was told what was below, I tossed a rock over the edge.

I never heard it hit the ground. It was probably too far for my ears to pick up and it was a windy day. But that—that convinced me. And the feeling of standing on the edge of something I couldn't fathom was truly frightening. And exhilarating.

The unknown. A future I can't predict. If I was told there was a path forwards, a thin ledge to stand on while the abyss howled around beneath me, would I have the courage to keep going?

I don't know. But this is my only choice. I, Laken Godart, am an [Emperor]. I know what I must do. There's no going back.

So I suppose...this would be a fine way to die.

Day 55

"Laken? Laken, wake up. You're snoring."

Someone pokes me and I wake up. I jerk upright, and look around. I don't bother opening my eyes. There are some reactions that I suppose some people instinctively perform, but eye-related activities are generally a waste of time for me. I can't see.

I can hear, however, so I turn my head and look slightly miffed in the direction the voice and the poke came from. It takes my brain a second to process why I was woken up, and then open my mouth to scold.

“Durene. I was having an enjoyable nap. What’s wrong with me snoring?”

“It’s not very noble. You said that an [Emperor] should be dignified in all situations. Snoring isn’t.”

I sigh and sit back. I’m back in reality and I can feel reality around me now. What was I thinking of? I was just dozing, remembering the past, perhaps. I remember a cliff...now I can feel a hard surface beneath me, and a rumbling and forward motion. I’m on a wagon, and it’s just past noon, or so I’m told.

“Snoring is a very human trait, Durene. Not just human either—it’s a natural thing everyone does. Even if I *am* an [Emperor], I’d expect anyone to understand that I snore and sleep like everyone else.”

“Yes, but you were also drooling. That’s not dignified.”

The voice, deep and female, points that out. I brush at my face and find she’s right. I scowl and sigh.

“Fine. I’ve stopped. But you could have just let me sleep. There’s no one to see me drooling, objectionable as that may be.”

“No, I think one of the adventurers is coming. So I had to wake you.”

Durene’s voice is self-assured and confident. I have to look my best when strangers are around, therefore I must be awake. I sigh, but give up the argument. Instead I lean back into my seat and center myself in the world. Where am I? What am I doing? I’m sitting in a wagon. Existential problems solved.

I’m on the road again. Or more accurately, I’ve been on the road for the last four days. If I’m honest, it’s not actually me on the road. I’m just sitting on a bumping wagon while a rather smelly horse pulls me along. Sitting in a very comfortable seat of padded cloth that Durene and Gamel worked up for me of course, but it does get boring.

Hi. I’m Laken. An [Emperor]. I’m currently travelling down a cleared road of dried mud, sitting in a wagon while my girlfriend—or perhaps lover

—walks beside the cart. She's too big to ride with me and Durene says she prefers to walk. I would too—it's good for the legs, but it's just a bit too likely that I'll have my foot crushed by a wagon wheel for me to risk it.

Honestly, a 1% chance of having my foot get run over by a rolling mass of several tons of weight is too much for me. So I sit and talk with her, or occasionally Gamel, who walks and sometimes sits on the wagon. He's one of my subjects, a young man from a village called Riverfarm.

“Mister Laken! I think we're only a few miles from Riverfarm if that's the place your man Gamel has described, sir!”

A voice shouts at me and I turn my head in the direction of the call. I raise a hand towards the adventurer. That's Beniar, the leader of the Windfrozen Riders. He's a [Rider], and one of the two Silver-rank adventurer groups that I hired to escort me and protect the village.

I hear hoof beats, and then someone rides up to the wagon. I sigh. Not because I'm unhappy about reaching Riverfarm—on the contrary, I can't wait to be back. One of the reasons why is because it means I'll have more space from Beniar. He's a chatterbox and annoying.

“Allow me to say, sir, that it's been a pleasure escorting you this far. I hope you'll recommend my team to the Merchant's Guild and for future assignments. Not that our job is ended—we'll be patrolling around your village for the month, as you know. So I hope to work together well with you, sir. Or is that my lord?”

I don't need eyes to hear the impudent tone in Beniar's voice, or know that Durene's probably scowling at him. To stop her from arguing with the young man, I smile in his direction.

“My lord is acceptable, Beniar. Sir, your majesty, or any other title you'd prefer to give me I would also be content with, however. Thank you for telling me. You may go.”

That throws him. I hear Beniar's horse lag behind for a moment, and then a cough. Durene giggles, his voice sounds strained.

“Ah, yes sir. We'll signal the village that we're arriving. I uh, well, I'll be going.”

He rides off. Durene starts laughing out loud and I think Beniar can hear her. I smile, but covertly, so that if he looks back he won't see.

"Shush, Durene. That's not nice. Beniar is a good sort, even if he's... inquisitive."

That doesn't stop Durene, of course. My half-Troll lover, protector, and sometimes nap-waker has not enjoyed Beniar's company. He's just a bit too fond of bragging about his accomplishments—which are decent, enough for his team to be called Silver-rank despite his age—and a bit too interested in who I am.

I arrived in Invrisil, the city of adventurers and one of the hubs of the northern part of the continent around a week ago. I caused a stir and spent lavishly at the Merchant's Guild there—buying supplies for Riverfarm, magic-users with flame spells to clear the snowy roads so I could ride back, and hired two Silver-rank teams to protect my village.

That's a lot of money, and a lot of influence to be used for a no-name village in the middle of nowhere. By the time I left the city, several days after Ryoka Griffin delivered aid to my village and then disappeared in a carriage owned by Magnolia Reinhart, rumors were flying about exactly who I was and what my interests were.

I received several invitations from reputable [Merchants], [Bankers], adventurers, and so on, and refused them all. Is it any wonder people like Beniar want to know if I'm some sort of rich lordling or other important figure? The information could be worth a lot and help a young adventurer with his career. So he's pestered me and bragged shamelessly on the four-day trip. I understand, but just wish he were as adept socially as he is with a sword.

Apparently I'm not the only person with that view. I hear an indignant murmur from my left, and then a voice. Gamel speaks up for the first time, and I hear the snow crunch as he paces to the left of my wagon. He has to work to keep up, unlike Durene, but he seems to think only I deserve the comfort of the wagon.

"He shouldn't be so direct with you, sire. He should be bowing and saying your majesty without it being a joke."

I sigh again as Durene voices her agreement from my left. Here I am with my two vassals who seem to think everyone should bow and kiss my smelly feet every two seconds. And soon, I'll be in the midst of a village full of them. How will I manage?

Well, I have a few ideas. And of course, I must manage. I am their [Emperor]. I accepted the responsibility when I saved Riverfarm from an avalanche. Getting the [Emperor] class was almost a joke, a chance decision. However, I have embraced what I am now. I have a duty. I cannot turn my back on it now.

So I straighten my back. I *am* an [Emperor]. And if I am, there are some things I have to get right. Starting now. After all, there is a problem with my subjects telling me how I should be treated. They mean well, but that's their opinion. I have mine, and they have to understand that. And obey.

"Gamel, I appreciate your input. And yours of course, Durene. But please understand this: I will be treated like a commoner, disrespectfully, flippantly, and sometimes rudely by the people I meet. That is not their fault. They do not know I am an [Emperor], or if they do, they might not believe. That does not mean you two should reprimand them. In fact, I insist you do not. I *order* you not to. Is that understood?"

Durene's laughter cuts off. I can't see Gamel, but I imagine him straightening up, flushing.

"I'm terribly sorry, sire."

"Enough of that. I told you, sir, or my name is fine."

"Yes...sir."

And here comes the hard part. I modulate my tone; try to explain why I say what I do. It's one thing to command, another to lead. I was told that just recently. I may be an [Emperor], but I must inspire and teach, not just tell.

"The reason why I say this is because titles are meaningless to me, Gamel. No, don't gape. I may be an [Emperor], but being called and treated like one isn't strictly necessary. Yes, I insist on respect, but that comes in a different way from people I meet. I would rather know how people feel about me than ruin their impressions of me and mine of them from the start.

Rudeness of course is different, and you can be offended about that. But simple ignorance or casual incivility is to be welcomed, I think.”

There’s a thoughtful silence from Gamel after that, and I hope I’ve reached him. However, Durene’s voice is troubled.

“But Laken, if you’re an [Emperor]—”

I raise a finger and she breaks off. Where has this come from? Durene’s changed a lot from the timid girl I met in the forest almost two months ago. Oh, she’s mainly the same, but she’s bolder now. She’s gotten a lot more opinionated—mostly about how I should be treated. That doesn’t mean she’s right of course.

“Durene, I understand your concerns. However, my ego is large enough that I don’t need to be called ‘your majesty’ every two seconds. Think of it from my perspective.”

“How do you mean?”

I smile slightly.

“I am an [Emperor]. You know that. Gamel knows that. And I know that. That fact will never change. Why should what other people say or believe matter? I know who I am. That’s all I need.”

“Wow.”

Durene’s voice sounds awed, and Gamel makes a similar noise. I sigh. It really wasn’t that special. It’s just about self-confidence. But perhaps neither Durene nor Gamel has ever thought about life in that way. They both grew up in a tiny village. Gamel can barely read; Durene can’t.

Neither one knows about psychology, economics, mathematics, germ theory...so much. They know a lot about living, and they’re good people who don’t need the rest to survive. But it could help them. So now and then I try to teach.

Unfortunately, every action has consequences. And my little speech has roused the final occupant of the wagon. I hear a screech and flapping wings. I sigh.

“Frostwing, shut up.”

The loud shrieking cuts off. I turn in my seat and get up onto my knees. It's not hard to find the perch anchored to the top of a bag of grain—although I do get my fingers in a bit of fresh bird droppings. I grimace and then find Frostwing. The bird recoils a bit from my touch, and then rubs her head against my palm.

Frostwing. I have a bird, by the way. She's just a fledgling, but she's getting bigger each day—she's already about as long as my hand and forearm. I wonder how large she'll get by the time she finishes growing.

She allegedly has blue feathers, the better to hide in the sky, I suppose. I'm still not sure if Durene's playing a trick on me. I keep thinking that blue is an odd color in a bird—but I can't remember what eagles and hawks are supposed to look like from my world. I...think they have brown and white feathers, but honestly, listening to descriptions of birds isn't like seeing them. It doesn't stick in the mind.

Or so I would imagine.

Right now it seems like Frostwing wants to learn to fly. She keeps flapping her wings on her perch as I find her head and stroke it. A beak pokes my hand gently and I sigh.

"I think she's hungry. Again. Gamel, do you have—"

"Some jerky. Here, sire."

Gamel's already got the dried meat ready. I break some off as Frostwing tries to snatch the entire strip from me. She's voracious, but I am her owner—and a [Beast Tamer], so I scold her and force her to take pieces from my hand one at a time.

I'm not sure this is how you raise birds, but hey, I'm giving it my best shot.

Lecturing Gamel and Durene, talking to nosy adventurers, and dealing with my pooping bird take up a good amount of time after I've woken up. However, I must admit that for an [Emperor], someone with a class who's supposed to rule over countless people and an empire, this isn't exactly very fulfilling. I'm restless, and I want to be in my village soon. There I'll be able to see...in a way.

And there's so much to do. I have a thousand and one things I know I have to take care of, but I've been confined to the wagon for the trip. When I am outside of the lands I own, I am blind and to some degree, helpless. This world is filled with monsters and I must rely on other people for help.

Like any good [Emperor], in fact. There's some irony to that. But I'm keenly aware that as loyal as Durene and Gamel are, and as faithful as the villagers of Riverfarm seem to be, they're not exactly capable of everything. None of them are fighters, although I wouldn't ever bet against Durene. But despite her having a [Paladin] class, she's never been in a life-or-death battle, and there are dangerous monsters in this world.

Not that I've ever seen one. I'm blind. If I'm in a situation where a monster is close enough for me to hear or touch, I'm probably dead since running away when blind is very, very difficult.

So the adventurers like Beniar are essential. Not just now, but in the future. I have thought and been advised on the future. That's why when the second adventurer rides towards my wagon, I make sure Frostwing's poop is off my hands and try to look as dignified as Durene thinks I should be.

"Mister Laken, may we have a word? It's me, ah, the leader of the Celestial Trackers."

I hear a young woman's voice, and then another as two adventurers ride down towards me from the wagons ahead. Did I mention the other wagons? Some of the adventurers not riding next to the wagon I'm on are filling the ones ahead and behind me. I, as an important person, get a wagon to myself.

"Certainly. Come by this side and we can talk."

I move over to the right side of the wagon and hear Durene making room for the horse. Someone else speaks politely to me, the owner of the second horse.

"I am here as well, sir."

I nod. I've met these two adventurers as well, and they're considerably easier to work with than Beniar is.

"Wiskeria and Odveig, right?"

“That’s right. We were hoping to speak with you about our duties when we reached the village, Mister Laken. Is now a bad time?”

“Certainly not. Did you have any concerns? What are your expectations from what the Merchant’s Guild hired you for?”

The two confer as I wait patiently. Odveig is the leader, a [Macewoman], and Wiskeria is her subordinate. They lead the Celestial Trackers. Well, Odveig is the one who calls herself the leader, but I feel like Wiskeria is the brains behind the group. She’s a [Witch], a specialized type of [Mage] who can apparently use spells to hinder her opponents, brew potions, and assist her friends.

In short, she’s fascinating and I’ve wanted to talk with Wiskeria, but haven’t had much time to do so. In the few interactions I’ve had with their team, I got the sense that Odveig is rightly paranoid that Wiskeria might take her place as the leader of the group. Wiskeria herself seems disinterested in the role of leader, but she’s far too sharp to be excluded from the decision-making process.

Which is why both of them are here now. Odveig is the first to speak to me. She has a husky voice, and a very pleasant tone with a slight accent on the ‘th’ sounds she makes.

“Generally, these sorts of contracts have us patrol an area by day and night, Mister Laken. We ah, are expected to be fed and given adequate shelter, but that’s all our contract entails. We can hunt and scavenge for our own provisions, but that generally takes up a good deal of the time we’re supposed to be guarding, you see...”

“Food is not an issue, Miss Odveig. And I’m sure we can find indoor spots for your entire group—unless you’d prefer camping in the tents you brought. As you know, there are not many buildings in the village that can be used, but we’ll try to accommodate you as best we can.”

“We do appreciate that, sir. May I ask what trouble you’re expecting? Hiring two Silver-rank teams is not—not—”

She stumbled on her words and Wiskeria took over. Her voice is quieter, smoother, and precise. It makes me think she’s had some kind of formal education—or perhaps it’s just her personality.

“Two Silver-rank teams are generally only called for when protecting areas at immediate risk of monster attacks, sir. To escort so many wagons two teams is quite appropriate, but we’re afraid our services might be considered wasted when guarding an entire village for a month.”

I smile. Do they fear inactivity, or that I’ll try to pay them less? Their fee has already been paid—half now, and half held by the Adventurer’s Guild when they return. Either way, I should reassure them.

“Call me paranoid, Miss Odveig, Miss Wiskeria. But I feel that two Silver-rank teams are better than one, and both are essential in case trouble comes to Riverfarm. That might not happen, in which case you’ll have a quiet month. However...if it does happen I’d rather be ready for it, which is why I’m willing to pay for the best.”

“You’ll get that, Mister Laken, rest assured!”

My words seem to reassure and invigorate Odveig, who I’m sure is sitting straighter on her saddle. Wiskeria takes a more measured response.

“In that case, we’ll set about ensuring there are no threats to the village, sir. And if there turns out to be no threats nearby...will you have us patrolling the entire duration?”

“That’s a good question. I wouldn’t like to waste your time, and if you find nothing, I’m sure your group doesn’t all need to scout at once. I’d be fine letting your groups train or...doing whatever you feel is necessary. However, my village is in need. Could your groups help rebuild? A few hands to help lift and carry things would be welcome.”

Another brief moment of whispering, and then Wiskeria speaks up.

“I’m sure our party can send some of our group to assist with whatever rebuilding is necessary, or lend our Skills where we can once we’re sure the area is secure, sir. I expect the Windfrozen Riders have useful Skills in their group as well. We may be able to hunt for game as well, once again, after ensuring the area is clear of monsters.”

“Excellent. I will speak with you when we reach the village, then. I’m told it’s just an hour or two away?”

“We should be arriving within the hour, sir.”

“Very good. Thank you.”

They withdraw. I sit back in the wagon and after a moment, Durene steps up next to me.

“You aren’t expecting trouble, are you, Laken? I’ve heard monsters and bandits like to prey on villages that get into trouble.”

Her voice is worried, and I nod while turning my head up to the sky. It’s still so *cold* out here! Winter in this world doesn’t play around. Thank goodness for blankets and thick coats.

“I had the same thought. That’s why we have two Silver-rank teams, Durene. They’ll deal with most problems quite easily, unless I miss my guess.”

“That’s true. I haven’t heard of any village rich enough to hire a Silver-rank team, let alone *two!*”

Durene’s voice beams with pride at that simple fact. I laugh, and lean back.

“Yes, yes. Don’t let it get to your head. I’m going to take a nap now, Durene. Without snoring or drooling, hopefully. Wake me when we get close to the village, will you?”

“Okay.”

It feels like I’ve just closed my eyes when a broad finger pokes me awake. I feel Durene jabbing me at the same time as I hear her voice.

“Laken! We’re here!”

I don’t need to be told that. The instant I sit up, I hear a huge mass of voices cheering like wild, making Frostwing wake up and panic on her perch. But that’s not the special bit.

The special bit is that I can *see* all the villagers cheering me, see the adventurers guarding the convoy of wagons gaping, see the people of Riverfarm rushing towards me, waving their arms and calling my name.

Well, *see* is a strong word. It’s more like a vision in my mind. A...sense, if you will. I call it sight because that’s the closest thing I can think of to this power I have.

As an [Emperor], I own Riverfarm. I claimed it to save the village, and as it turns out, whatever land I possess, I can sense, down to the smallest

rock. I know instinctively that Riverfarm has eight buildings that have been excavated of snow—three more than when I left—and nearly thirty buildings still buried beneath. I can sense Durene hovering by the wagon and beaming while Gamel stands up on another and waves to his sweetheart.

I can see. That's the gift of my class and it is worth beyond worth to me. However, my 'sight' has its limits. I see expressions, open mouths, and so on. Moving outlines of people too, but there is no color in my mind, and no detail. It's more like what I imagine a bat's echolocation might describe the world as. I see shapes, but not nuance.

It's good enough. It's more than enough. However, it means I do still need to rely on others for some things. I stand up from the wagon and hear the villagers shouting my name.

"Laken! [Emperor] Laken!"

"Your majesty!"

"Our [Emperor] has returned! Praise Emperor Laken!"

"The Unseen Empire! Emperor Laken!"

That last cry makes me start a bit. The Unseen Empire? Now how did they...? Oh, right! I once claimed Riverfarm as part of the Unseen Empire. It's a fitting name, if embarrassing.

However, the cheering is genuine and it puts a smile on my face. I don't deserve it, but I did save a lot of the village after the avalanche. I'm touched by their belief in me. I raise a hand, and they go wild.

I imagine this is what being a celebrity feels like. As I step down from the wagon people rush to surround me. I clasp hands, let people gently touch me, and then Durene and Gamel are forcing people to stand back. And just like that, the wild exuberance turns into deference as the villagers form a path for me to enter the village.

I can sense Prost waiting with some of the older villagers. I'm anxious to talk to him, but I can't help it. I nudge Durene and she bends down so I can whisper to her.

"Psst, Durene. Describe the faces of the other adventurers to me."

I can sense them, well, most of them, the ones within the village's radius. In my picture of the world all of the adventurers are standing stock still, gaping. However, I want to know what their expressions are like. I can sense Durene as she straightens, and then I hear her voice, full of merry laughter.

"They can't believe it! Beniar's face is—I think his eyes are going to pop out of his head! And Odveig looks like she's going to choke!"

She sounds gleeful. In fact, Durene might have been waiting for this moment. I never mentioned my true nature to Odveig or Beniar—people assumed I was some sort of noble, or a very rich stranger, but an [Emperor]? I can't imagine what they're thinking at the moment. I nudge Durene one more time.

"And Wiskeria?"

"Oh. She's...staring at you."

"Does she seem surprised?"

"Yeah, but she's not gaping or anything...why?"

"Nothing much. I just wanted to see how she'd react. Quick thinking and being able to adjust to any situation is important."

"Okay?"

She doesn't get it, but Wiskeria is already part of my plans. I stride towards Prost and the other villagers as people shout my name.

Emperor Laken. I guess I can't hide that fact any longer. And as I think that, I wonder if Wiskeria or the other two [Mages] in the adventurer groups can cast the [Message] spell. If they can...word about me might be spreading very quickly.

I smile faintly. Oops. The secret's out of the bag. Not that I had any real hopes of keeping my class secret. But the dice have been cast. What will happen next?

It's odd, but I actually think I know.

Day 56

The first day after I came back to Riverfarm was pure chaos, plain and simple. It was already late when I returned, and between hearing Prost and the other villagers fall over themselves to thank me—and assure me they hadn't eaten all of the food Ryoka had brought—I was hard pressed to get a word in.

Or rather, because I'm an [Emperor], my words cause a complete hush and everyone has to listen to what I say, rather than let my voice be one of the many and get work done. Ah, well, we had a banquet on that first night and that's probably all I was going to get done anyways.

A celebration to welcome an [Emperor] back. More than that, a celebration because I brought back exactly what I promised. Food for Riverfarm, supplies, tools to help rebuild, and adventurers to keep them safe. Everything the village needed to start rebuilding.

And now it's the day after. I slept like I was in a five-star hotel in Durene's cottage. My blankets and pillow felt like they were made of silk or clouds, and I woke up feeling full of energy. That's thanks to my Skill as an [Emperor]—[Empire: Blessing of the Hearth]. It makes sleeping pleasant, even if you only have the floor and some blankets for a bed.

I'm grateful for that. My subjects need their rest, and lots of energy. Because today I'm going to start...everything.

"Laken, do you want eggs?"

"Sure, Durene. Give me some bacon too. No, Frostwing, you can't have any. This is my bacon. Peck me, and I'll halve your breakfast, understand?"

Breakfast is quick, serene, and over in a flash. Once I leave the cottage I find several people waiting for me. Waiting in the cold, although not in the snow since Durene shoveled her pathway this morning.

Prost, Gamel, Odveig, Beniar, and Wiskeria are all waiting for me by the time I come out with Durene. I'm surprised Gamel's here, but I suppose he thinks of himself as my personal manservant. Prost speaks for the villagers, so his presence makes sense. As for the adventurers...well, at least they're ready to work.

"Ah, Mister—that is to say, Emperor—ah—"

Beniar calls out hesitantly as I walk towards him, a smile on my face. I can hear him tripping over his words and imagine his blush. Gamel and Prost bow deeply to me as soon as I come near, and the other adventurers awkwardly imitate them.

I think they're still reeling from the revelation that I'm an [Emperor], to be honest. Well, it makes sense. In their world, a class defines who you are. So if I have an [Emperor] class...I'm an [Emperor]. Simple as that.

"Let's not dwell on formalities, Beniar. I told you any form of address was suitable. Sir works well."

"Ah. Oh? Yes sir! Uh—"

Wiskeria clears her throat. She seems the least tongue-tied, as I had expected. I glance towards her and notice how she's watching me. I think the other adventurers are surprised as well; I've forgone my walking cane and move about surely on Durene's land. Because of course, I can see as well as anyone else now. Better, perhaps.

Whatever her thoughts, Wiskeria politely bows her head as she speaks. She doesn't stumble over her words.

"Do you have orders for us, sire? We've made a small camp next to the village and we've got a good sense of the immediate area. We only need your word to start scouting the landscape. If we could speak with some of the locals who know the area, that would help as well."

I nod thoughtfully. Adventurers...I have a lot I'd like to talk to them about, especially Wiskeria, but for now I need to talk to Prost more. So I let them do their job.

"If your group will divide the scouting and patrolling with the Windfrozen Riders, I'd be most grateful. I believe I will talk with Odveig and Beniar more specifically about their duties later—but as you can see I have a lot to do."

"Of course, sire. We'll get to work right away."

Wiskeria nods to Odveig, and then has to drag both her and Beniar away. They're still staring, which I have to say, I'm getting more used to. I turn to Prost as Durene joins me with Frostwing perched on her shoulder. The bird pecks at Durene's cheek as I smile at Prost.

“Farmer Prost. How has the village been since I left? I’m told you got the food I had delivered to you alright—did you have an enjoyable Christmas? I hope my Runner, Ryoka, explained what that was.”

Prost starts, and I think he’s surprised at my warm greeting. Well, we did have an unpleasant first few encounters where he was against me and Durene living together. After I saved the village he was falling over himself to help me, and his attitude’s much better. For my part, I haven’t forgotten the past, but Prost lost his youngest boy in the avalanche. That kind of pain...no, I would never hold a grudge after all that has happened.

“Miss Ryoka, your majesty? Oh, she came by not a week ago—we were so grateful for her arrival we wept, sire. It was a blessing, and the food she brought—I know I said it too much yesterday, but the village can’t thank you enough, your majesty.”

“Sir, or sire’s fine, Mister Prost. Don’t worry about the titles—I’ve told Gamel the same. But now I’m back, and I’ve got all I promised.”

“More food and supplies? Your m—sire, I have to tell you that we’ve been rationing what Miss Ryoka brought. We made sure to not overeat, and I think we could stretch it till the spring if that’s all that could be bought.”

Responsible, thoughtful...the villagers of Riverfarm aren’t idiots, for all they once were small-minded. You can’t be stupid and live out here, where a bad harvest might mean starvation if you hadn’t planned ahead. I wave a hand and start heading down to the village, speaking to Durene, Prost, and Gamel all at once.

“Ryoka delivered a good bit of food, but hardly all of what I bought, Mister Prost. Don’t fear, we’ve enough food to last us the winter and a good ways into the spring. However, making sure we have food for the times after that is one of our biggest priorities right now.”

“Yes sir. We’ve been digging out more of the buried buildings, but it’s painfully slow work...but with you and Durene here, I’m sure we’ll do all that needs doing!”

“About that. I think clearing the snow is a good start, and so I hope I can ask you, Durene, to help. Gamel can also lend a hand...I’ll speak with Mister Prost about other matters, unless there’s something pressing?”

“Nope! I can do that, Laken. I’m ready for work, and there’s an extra-large shovel in the wagons I can use!”

Durene’s clearly ready for hard work, and she hands Frostwing to Gamel, who’s gotten used to handling the cranky bird. I nod to Gamel. If he’s my assistant—and he’s very loyal and does what I ask him to—then I should use him as one.

“Can you ask Odveig and Beniar if their [Mages] can use their spells to melt the snow, Gamel? I know you know some fire magic, but I believe some experienced spellcasters might help quite a bit with the excavation.”

“At once, sire.”

He and Durene head towards the village. I can sense the villagers waiting for me, but a few shouted words from Prost and they disperse. After shouting greetings at me, of course. I walk slowly with Prost around the village, making my way over huge drifts of snow.

The avalanche that hit Riverfarm buried almost all of it. Some houses were only half-consumed by the snow, but in the first few days after the disaster the villagers couldn’t walk without sinking into the deep snow. At the moment there’s a good section of the village that’s been cleared of snow, but there are still walls of hard snow and ice.

Prost is busy showing me the new houses the villagers have dug out. I can sense how battered the buildings are. Oh, the supports have held in most, but the wood is broken in countless places from the sheer force behind the avalanche. It will take a lot of doing to restore the buildings to any sense of working order, and there are still fields buried in the snow, dead animals still frozen where they were engulfed, scattered tools and belongings...

“It’s a mess, Emperor Laken. I’d despair at restoring anything at all if you weren’t here, I really would. Most villages suffer a disaster like this and, well, it’s over. We’d have to pack up and move, what few of us survived. It’s that or starve or freeze or be eaten by monsters.”

“Not exactly a pleasant choice, Mister Prost. However, even with what I brought, rebuilding Riverfarm will be a chore and a half. I hope everyone knows that.”

“Aye, we do. Don’t fear sire, we’re no strangers to hard work and we’ll do whatever you think is best.”

I can sense Prost nodding as he takes me around the barn, the main hub of the new village. There are simple beds inside, piles of recovered goods, several cooking fires outside...rudimentary stuff, but at least the villagers sleep like rocks. Everything else will have to be remade, and I’m the one in charge. Oh dear.

“Let’s get down to business, then, Prost. I’ve got some good ideas on how to proceed, but I’d love to hear what you’d do in a situation like this.”

I’ve got more than just a few ideas. I’ve spoken to several people, Ryoka among them, who gave me excellent advice on what to do. And honestly, I needed it. Rebuilding a village and managing everyone is not among the skills I brought from Earth, from my world, but I feel oddly confident now.

Prost shakes his head in response to my question. He has to break off to tell someone where the hammers are—in the wagons and two in the barn—and then he tells a group of young men and women to go help dig where Durene’s at. He’s in charge, as are a few of the older villagers. But that’s in charge under me, I feel. If I wasn’t here, would things go this well?

“Honestly, your majesty? I wouldn’t know where to begin, aside from digging out what I can. There’s so many farms ruined...I supposed I’d try to dig up fields, get as much land cleared as possible so I could sow all the plants I could after the last frost, but that’s all I know. I’d be hoping to trade what valuables I could gather for supplies, some chickens and other animals maybe, but I wouldn’t know where to start. I’m glad you’re here, sir.”

“I find your faith in me disturbing, Mister Prost. I’m no miracle worker.”

“Say that to my daughter, sir. And my wife. You saved them and over half the village. But for you we’d be dead.”

Prost turns to me, and grips my shoulder before he remembers I’m an [Emperor] and starts apologizing. I stop him. That’s right. That’s why people have faith in me. Because I saved lives. I cannot betray that faith, although it’s more than any person should have placed on them.

“Well, we’ll see if my ideas work. For now...let’s talk about the villagers, Prost. What do you think they need?”

“Need? Well, you’ve given us warm bellies and your Skill makes us feel as though we’re sleeping on pure cotton, sire. Give us some more rooms and a place to work and I’d say that’s all I need. With these adventurers around, we don’t have to fear monsters and that’s a relief.”

I smile as I find a place to stand with Prost, out of the way. I can sense villagers staring at me as they work.

“Interesting. You thought of that off the top of your head, didn’t you, Mister Prost?”

“Yes sire. I just said what I could think of.”

“And what you could think of were the essentials. Food, shelter, and security. I’d say those are the three basic elements all people need to survive, don’t you, Mister Prost?”

“I’d agree with that, sire. That and a good drink now and then.”

I grin and see Prost smiling in relief. An [Emperor] needs to be human too.

“Well, that’s my point. In rebuilding Riverfarm, I’m looking at the essentials first, Mister Prost. Not just for now, but for the future when the supplies are gone and the adventurers leave.”

I start ticking off points on my hand as Prost listens.

“We need space for the people—not just somewhere they can live for the moment, but permanent homes. We need to grow food and raise animals, enough for the village to survive on. And we need a way to defend ourselves if monsters attack. Now, two of those issues can be solved by building the village again. However...it’s occurred to me that here might not be the best place to build it.”

I gesture towards the nearest house. Half of it has been collapsed inwards, and the other half is badly damaged and just patched over with boards to keep the wind out.

“The buildings we uncover are damaged. Some of the supports have shifted, the walls are blown out and the foundation’s destroyed on some of

them. It would be just as much work to fix one up as make a new one, I'm thinking. Plus...I'm not sure the villagers would like to live in a place where so much grief has been caused."

Most of the villagers buried in the avalanche were trapped in their houses, suffocated or bashed to death when it happened. The digging teams I led had to cut through roofs and dig to find the doors in order to save lives...or recover the bodies.

Prost nods heavily.

"That's true, sire. But then where would we build the village? We've lived here all our lives, most of us."

"I understand. And I'm not suggesting we abandon this place, but digging out houses takes time, and I'd rather have some of the villagers building new ones. It can't be fun sleeping crammed together, even with my Skill. So what if we...drew up some blueprints for a new village right now?"

"Blueprints?"

"A simple map. I can't see well, but let's assume Riverfarm is here. And if we're rebuilding the village, why not make it efficient? We can put all the fields together here, rather than each farmer have their own. And houses could go here...feel free to tell me if I'm making sense, Mister Prost."

In a few minutes Prost and I are scuffing at the ground with a stick, plotting out a village in the wet dirt. I can't sense the impressions in the ground unless they're fairly deep, but it's simple enough for Prost to get a handle of my idea, and then he's off with it.

"We could certainly build more houses like you're suggesting, sire. The ground's uneven over here, but if we had a few [Diggers] or Durene picked up a shovel, I don't see why we couldn't smooth over parts and—and well, the village could be twice as large as before! And the fields—some of us [Farmers] have talked the idea over, and some fields we could all work on is an enticing idea, 'specially if we combined teams of oxen. We never tried the idea because we quarreled over sharing the harvests, but if it's all of us working in the village together, I don't see why not."

"Excellent."

I have an idea of Riverfarm in my head. It's got a river running by the village, which is where the name comes from, but until recently the villagers had a very small plot of land they'd tamed and farmed on. The new village, the rebuilt one would expand that space and create a space with larger fields, more houses...and more organized structure, too. There would be a main road and houses would be adjacent to one another, rather than built wherever the original owners wanted them.

Prost and I stare at the blueprints in the dirt for a few seconds, before reality hits. The older man sits back on his haunches and shakes his head slowly.

"It's a grand idea you're thinking of, sire. But can it be done? We've a few folks with Skills in woodworking and building, and I reckon Durene could lift up a beam herself, but it's such a large thought I can't imagine it. You think it can be done? Truly?"

I smile. Here's one of my tests. Prost doubts we can do this. I do too, honestly—my ideas are so nebulous, I can't figure out how to put them into action. However, I'm a leader and so I have to reassure him. And myself.

"A new village? Why not? There are trees aplenty in the forests, and I know we have people with [Carpenter] classes here. We can build the houses one at a time and create a new village while the adventurers guard us and we live off of what I brought from Invrilil."

I reach out and clasp Prost on the shoulder, making him start.

"Remember, Mister Prost, we're not doing this by ourselves. A house is a challenge for a single person or a family, but a village? We could put up the first house in a matter of days or less. Why don't we do it like this? We'll build three houses, lay foundations, and get to work measuring, cutting wood, and so on, while we reclaim the village from the snow. We build them where we planned...and go from there. Sound good?"

"When you put it like that, sire, I can't help but think it sounds easier. Truly."

Prost nods as he stands up. He's hesitant, but now I've reduced the problem to a manageable one to him, he's already thinking of who has the best Skills to start work.

That's what I need. Because I don't know the villagers well enough myself. I go with Prost out of the village limits, towards the new building spots. Halfway there I pause and grimace.

"Something the matter, sire?"

I hear Prost's voice, but I can no longer sense him. I've gone...well, blind again. I must have left the village's limits.

"I think I'll have to stay here, Mister Prost. You check the spot we were discussing and see if it's usable. I'll wait here."

Prost leaves and I kick at the invisible boundary where my sense of the world starts to fade away in my head.

"This might be a problem."

My [Emperor]'s senses don't extend outside of the limits of the village. The land I claim is the only place where they work. Which is a problem whenever I go travelling, or in cases like now.

I have an idea about how to fix that. Well, I didn't come up with the idea. But still.

It's something for later, though. Prost comes back with the news that the spots I suggested would work. He's talking about asking the Fairfield family to help out, and getting Gamel and a few of the 'lads' to get some axes to cut down a few good trees—only the best wood will do, obviously, so we'll need to find someone with a good eye for it.

I take a breath and cut Prost off. There's something I've been meaning to do, something I've been advised to do. It might work, and if it does, it'll help Riverfarm—and me.

"Mister Prost, there's one last thing we need to talk about. That's why I wanted to talk alone with you."

Instantly the man becomes wary. He clears his throat.

"I uh, wondered if it might come to this, sire. About Durene...I can't say how sorry I am about how I behaved. And the others too. But myself...I can't apologize. I can only ask for—"

"What? Oh. Not that."

I wave a hand at Prost, surprising him. He blinks, and I shake my head.

“What? But sire—the way I behaved—”

“I’m not going to berate you for the past, Mister Prost. Not now. Not after what’s happened. What you’ve all lost. No. That would be petty, and cruel, I think. You’re trying to make amends. I know you apologized to Durene and frankly...no. There’s something else I want to speak to you about.”

“Yes, sire?”

He sounds more nervous, if that’s possible. I try to reassure him, but give up and get into it. I walk with Prost around the edge of the village, feeling my sense of the world dim and brighten as I stumble through deep snow. Prost walks with me, tense, watching me. But trusting, too. He trusts me.

“I’m going to rule the village. I claimed it, and I am an [Emperor]. I’m a bit surprised you all would want me to lead you—”

I silence Prost as he opens his mouth again.

“—But I understand. However, I’m not experienced. I’m a low-level [Emperor] and frankly, I have no idea how to build anything. I’m not a [Farmer] and Durene knows more about raising animals than me. I need someone with all these Skills to help me coordinate the villagers.”

“Milord, I’m happy to do what I can. Me and the other older folk—we’re at your disposal. And young Gamel seems to be growing up right quick. If you need something, all you have to do is ask.”

“Yes, but asking means I have to think of it. And there are things I won’t think of, Mister Prost. That’s why I need a second-in-command. Someone who can do the thinking—and the asking—without me.”

I hear Prost gulp as he understands what I’m getting at.

“And that person who’s doing the asking...is that me, sir? Why me? I know I’ve taken it upon myself to take our orders, but I’m hardly like our last [Village Head]. I’m no leader.”

I nod. A [Village Head] is a type of [Leader], if a weak one. I suppose I fill that role, but an [Emperor] is too large to lead a village. All my Skills

would apply to my empire, not an individual farm. Which is why...

“I know that. You are a [Farmer], Mister Prost. A good one, I think. Well thought of, but a farmer nonetheless. I need a leader, someone who can inspire people and manage them in my stead. Which is why I’m asking if you would take on another class for me.”

“Another—another class, sire? You mean become the village’s head? I reckon I could, but I’d only be Level 1, and you’re an [Emperor]—”

“No, not that. I mean, take on another class that I gave you. [Steward], to be exact.”

“[Steward]? *Me?*”

Prost stops in his tracks. He stares at me.

“But I—[Steward] is a noble title, sir! It’s as close to a lordship as—most [Kings] appoint a [Lord] as a [Steward]! I’m not worthy of such a class!”

“Yes, well, I could make you a [Lord] too, but I think that’s too many classes to handle at once. Don’t gape, Mister Prost. I said I wasn’t going to do it.”

“But—why me, sire? Why me?”

I stop in the cold snow and run a hand through my hair. I look at Prost, and wish I could see him, not just sense what his face is roughly doing.

“Why not? A ruler needs a [Steward], someone to manage their affairs. I am an [Emperor]—why shouldn’t I be able to give you that class? I made Durene a [Paladin]. If you’re willing, I’ll name you as my [Steward] and put you in command of all of Riverfarm. Under me, of course.”

He pauses for a long time in the snow. I think...no, I can’t tell what he’s thinking. But when Prost speaks, I can hear the wobble in his voice. The uncertainty, back again.

“I’m not worthy, sire. No—your majesty. Emperor Laken. I wouldn’t have imagined you were such a man, to be honest, but I can see it in you now. But sire, I know myself and *I* am not worthy of the class. I couldn’t be a [Steward], not a good one. I know that. You know that.”

I shake my head.

“No. You are not worthy. I agree with you on that, Mister Prost. However...none of us are. I need a [Steward], and you are the only person I can think who might fill that role. Gamel is too young, and I don't know the others. But you? You are a man people trust. A man I think I can trust. And you have that one quality which makes me believe in you.”

“What's that?”

He stares at me, hungry for an answer, words that can reassure him. I look into Prost's eyes and open mine. Just for a moment. He flinches as he stares into my pupils, but he meets my gaze. And I speak from the heart.

“Change. I have seen you change. If you can change from a man who refused to accept that I could love a half-Troll, Durene, to a man who calls me [Emperor], then perhaps you can also become a man worthy of leading others. Because you must. You are needed, Prost Surehand. The village needs you. Your family needs you. I need you. Will you help me?”

For a long time he's still. So long in fact that my eyes hurt and I have to close them. I'm not used to keeping them open. But I can still sense Prost there. At last he does speak.

“I'm not—but you know that. Milord, my [Emperor]...you say you need me. I...I'm humbled.”

There are tears in his voice and on his cheeks. They freeze in the cold. Prost bows towards me, deep.

“If you ask, I will do my best. I cannot promise...that is all I can do.”

“That is all I ask. In that case, Prost, kneel if you would.”

He goes to his knees in the snow. I reach out. There's no grand pronouncement on my part, no long ceremony. I speak and it is done.

“You are my [Steward]. Manage my village, Prost. Direct my people. I have faith in you.”

Tears fall into the snow. Prost stands.

“Will I gain the class tonight?”

“I think so.”

I have a suspicion. A hint. Prost wipes at his eyes and blows his nose on his sleeve. I smile, and bring him back into reality.

“Alright then. Let’s get to work.”

The moment passes. Prost and I head back to the village and we’re consumed by people. People, villagers with no idea what to do or what tomorrow holds. But they look towards me, and as Prost raises his voice and steps forwards, ordering the folks he knows around and dealing with minor squabbles, small complaints, they look towards him as well.

All in all, not a bad start.

Day 57

The next day I’m nearly shaken to death as Durene seizes me out of my bed and rattles me around.

“*Laken! Laken!* You won’t believe what’s happened to Mister Prost! He gained a class! And—and lost his levels!”

“What? What? Stop shaking me, Durene! Put me down and tell me what’s happened.”

Having a half-Troll lover is a wonderful thing in many ways. But when she’s excited, Durene is fully capable of lifting me up like a kitten. And I, like kittens, do not take well to being shaken.

When I’m on the ground and sipping some tea, Durene spills the entire event to me, which everyone in the village has already heard of. Prost went to sleep late last night and heard himself get a new class—[Steward].

That doesn’t surprise me, although it’s similar to someone winning the lottery as far as the other villagers are concerned. This class makes Prost important, just as being an [Emperor] makes me important. After all, [Stewards] are hardly common. Well, not in this world. Airline stewards are hardly anything to write about...but I digress. The thing that makes me sit up and has Durene in more of a frenzy is the other thing that happened to Prost, though.

“He lost his levels! All of his levels in [Farmer] and [Builder]—and the one level he had in [Trader]! It’s all *gone*! And he leveled up eight times as a [Steward]! Can you believe it? *Can you believe*—oh, sorry. I didn’t mean to shake you again!”

When I’ve gotten the hot tea cleaned off of me, I get the fine details. Last night Prost lost all his [Farmer] levels, and he had been a Level 20 [Farmer], as well as the few levels he had in other classes. In exchange, he became a Level 8 [Steward] right off the bat.

No one in Riverfarm had ever experienced anything like it. I hadn’t either, but I knew what it was.

“It’s called class consolidation, Durene.”

“That’s what Prost said! I heard about it—like how a [Commander] could take the [Soldier] class and [Sergeant] class and turn it into one thing, but—all of Prost’s levels? They’re all gone and...he only gets eight?”

“I think it’s because all of his farming experience doesn’t transfer over into being a [Steward], Durene. It gives him some insights, but it is a sacrifice. Mind you, he can still farm and I think he’ll have some of his Skills or all of them still, but he’s got a new class now that supersedes his old ones.”

Durene is tearing at her hair, practically out of her mind with all these revelations. She paces around the cottage, and now she stops and stares at me.

“Wait, you *knew* that was going to happen, Laken? How?”

I smile mysteriously and tap at my lips.

“Let’s just say I had an inkling, Durene. As for the how...I’ll tell you later. How’s Prost taking the change? Never mind, let’s go find him. I’ll have breakfast in the village.”

We hurry out of her cottage. For once no one’s waiting to greet me—everyone’s too busy gawking at Prost. He’s at the center of attention in the village.

It seems his family, his two surviving daughters and wife regard his loss of levels as a terrible thing—but more than made up for by taking a ‘superior’ class. When everyone finds out that I’m the one behind Prost’s

class, I think they might mob me, demanding how I did it and asking—hinting, rather—that they would love to be a [Lord] or [Knight] or so on. Prost has to assert his new class and Skills to restore order.

After a while, we get back to work. Prost has several valuable new Skills, all of which he confides in me and no one else. Chief among them are [Talent Finder], and [Eye of Need], which helps him find the people best suited for a task, whether they know it or not. He can also tell what we're low on and what issues are most critical and require attention.

In short, he's turned overnight from a [Farmer] into someone with the right skillset for what I need. The change in his class doesn't change him as a person, but it's terrifying to see how competent and sure of himself he became from me telling him he had a different class.

That knowledge and the knowledge that the advice I was given was right weighs on my mind for all of twenty minutes before the adventurers get my attention. Beniar and Odveig have apparently nominated Wiskeria to talk to me, perhaps because she's the most well-spoken.

I don't care, but it gives me an opportunity to get another measure of her as she delivers her report. The adventurers have traveled in every direction for quite a few miles thanks to the Windfrozen Rider's mounts, and found any number of spots devastated by the avalanche, but few dangers to speak of.

"We uncovered what looks like a bear's den in the hills, but there's no other large animals or monsters nearby. We'll keep an eye on it, but the bear should stay put until the spring. With your permission, we'll range further afield and try to bring back some fresh meat."

Wiskeria's report is concise and to the point. She gives me her opinion that the village is safe from all but opportunistic scavenger animals—the occasional fox and squirrel—and the adventurers are already growing restless, looking for a challenge.

I give her full rein to have some of the adventurers hunt and others help with the village, and then bring up a topic more important to me.

"I hope you and the others weren't too surprised by my, ah, class. I didn't mean to keep it hidden, but the attention would have been troublesome in Invisil. Are you surprised, Wiskeria?"

The [Witch] pauses for a moment before she replies.

“I am...amazed, your majesty. I hope my team has not offended you in any way. Odveig was worrying, and I think Beniar is afraid to speak with you.”

I listen to her voice. Wiskeria's tone is straightforward, but there's not as much stunned incredulity in her tone as there is in the other adventurers when I speak to them. I shake my head.

“I took no offense. But I hope your teams can be counted on to be a bit discreet?”

“Of course, sir. If you wish it, none of us will speak about your class.”

I smile.

“And you haven't already sent back word to Invril that I'm an [Emperor]?”

This time I sense Wiskeria hesitate. Aha.

“I—”

“I don't mind. Just please know that I'd prefer an unpleasant truth to a lie to my face.”

“Yes, your majesty. My deepest apologies.”

She bows her head and I feel uncomfortable. I cough.

“I imagine you have some questions about why I choose to settle in Riverfarm. And who I am, I suppose.”

“A...few. Would you indulge me, sire?”

She's looking at me. I smile again.

“I'm afraid that whatever questions you have will have to wait, Wiskeria. However, I do want to talk with you soon about what I'm doing here and what the Celestial Trackers and the Windfrozen Riders might gain from staying here longer.”

A pause. Then Wiskeria's voice.

“You want us to stay here. To become your subjects.”

She's sharp. I cover my reaction with a delicate nod.

“It’s an offer I’m thinking of. I’m not asking you to decide right away. And if you think it would bother the others, by all means wait before telling them. I’d just like you to watch what’s going on here. And then decide.”

I left Wiskeria with that. I can’t force her to do anything, and there’s so much I have to do. I’ll show her what Riverfarm could be by doing. And learn more about her too. But what was it I was told? Ah, yes. An empire is built upon the strength of its subjects. I need more than Riverfarm’s villagers if I want to create someplace safe.

It really *was* good advice I got.

Day 59

I was in the center of the village, going over plans for the new village with Prost when it happened. The bear that the Celestial Trackers had found woke up. It may have been hungry, or perhaps the avalanche changed whatever internal clock it was using for hibernation. Maybe it was just pissed off, but the results were the same.

The bear came down into the village. That might not sound like much, but I think anyone who’s ever seen a bear up close would understand.

“Bear attack!”

“*Get to safety!*”

“Dead gods, look at the size of it! It’s not a bear! It’s a Mossbear!”

“Get around it! Wiskeria, cast a spell! Someone get me my horse!”

Adventurers scatter and horns blow as the scouts on the perimeter sight the bear and raise the alarm. The bear, or rather Mossbear might have just woken up, but it charges into the village with incredible speed.

From my position in the center of the village, I can sense the villagers rushing away from the bear. Prost is busy shouting for people to retreat to the barn as adventurers try to form up. Some charge the bear and strike at it from the side. It turns, knocks a girl with a sword across the ground with a single paw and roars as an arrow bounces off of its fur.

“Oh shit.”

I can ‘see’ the bear’s form as it scatters the adventurers. It is easily three times as large as the biggest warrior here, and it looks like a tank made out of fur and muscle. Its coming right in my direction, too, towards where all the food in the barn is kept—and all the people.

“Fire! I mean, loose the arrows and get me a fire spell!”

“It’s not working! It’s too wet and the fur is too thick!”

Adventurers are loosing arrows at the bear and I can see Beniar running for his horse. But the problem is that a bear of this size is a huge armored target with all of its fur. Wiskeria scorches it with a spell and another adventurer mage hurls shards of stone at it—the bear just roars and keeps coming.

Towards me. At some point I realize I should run, but it is far too late. The bear is moving across the ground faster than I can run. I look around, searching for somewhere to hide where it can’t reach me. Then a huge figure *slams* into the bear from the side. I hear a roar almost as bestial as the bear and see Durene.

I’d forgotten how tall Durene is, and how large. She towers over the other adventurers as she grabs the bear, *punches* it, and sends it reeling backwards. One of the adventurers lashes at the bear’s side with a sword, barely cutting into it, but a second punch from Durene makes the bear back up.

It rises on two legs and tries to slam its entire weight on Durene. She grabs a paw and head-butts it. The bear growls, tries to bite Durene’s neck, and then claws her as she dodges.

Its claws are sharp, and they cut into her arm. Durene cries out and I sense blood hitting the ground. But she doesn’t fall back. She raises a fist as Beniar races towards the bear. It’s growling, and I know how dangerous bears can be. I don’t realize I’m running forwards until the bear is right in front of me.

“Stop!”

My voice is a shout, and I can feel the command in my tone strike the bear. And everyone else as well. Durene, Beniar—his horse slows and the

world pauses around me. The bear stops too. It stares at me, making a faint noise that's half warning, half inquisitive.

“Stop.”

I stare at the bear, quivering as I sense how huge it is. Durene's got a handful of its fur, but it looks like it could savage her in a moment if it gets the upper hand. How would the adventurers kill it? It would be a terrible battle and there are too many innocents around. I stare at the bear.

It's starting to move. My command only works for a moment. And the bear is hurt now, angry. It growls at me and I see Durene take a firmer grip on it. Her fist is clenched. She's unarmed. My [Paladin]. Why haven't I gotten her a weapon?

This is my battle as much as hers. I stare at the bear. And then I open my eyes. I stare, sightless, at the huge bear. I can feel an...intensity in my gaze. Something stronger, frightening. A Skill. [Intimidating Glare].

“Begone. Go back to your home. Leave my subjects alone.”

The bear whines. It's not aggressive. I stare at it, forcing myself to keep up the intensity, project my will. It's a battle of wills. I'm a [Beast Tamer] in this moment and an [Emperor]. I tell the bear that I am not food. My village is not food. I speak to it.

And it obeys. The bear twists and Durene lets go. It slowly begins to lope out of the village, into the forest. Adventurers hurriedly make way.

“I'll take a force and go after it!”

Beniar is the first to recover. He gestures at the others and I stop him.

“No. Don't antagonize it. That bear could kill some of you—leave it be for now. I don't think it's coming back.”

He hesitates, and then bows his head towards me. I stumble backwards, and someone catches me.

“You scared me to death! Don't do that! What if you'd gotten hurt?”

“You did get hurt!”

I reach towards Durene as she cradles me in her arms. I know she's wounded. I can feel the blood and hear her beating heart. Durene grunts as

she puts a hand over the gashes on her arm. I feel anxiously at them. They're not thick, but I demand a healing potion for Durene, despite her objections.

Gamel rushes towards me with a potion. Odveig and Wiskeria approach with deepest apologies and explanations for why the bear could have woken up so suddenly. I calm everyone down, assure the adventurers I'm not angry, talk with them about safeguards, have a watch posted on the cave, and life resumes.

It's moments like that which break up the day and make you realize how special life is. Which is why Durene and I retired to my cottage for a few hours.

Ahem. Afterwards, I ponder the encounter with the bear as Durene lies beside me in bed. It was startling and frightening to me more than the others for one reason.

I hadn't sensed it coming. Oh, I'd known the instant the bear entered the village's radius, but the adventurers had already raised the alarm. I hadn't known the bear was coming. If I didn't sense that, what else might happen that I'm unaware of?

The bear. It's apparently a Mossbear, a subspecies of the regular bear group that's bigger and tougher than usual. Magic plus biology comes up with some scary stuff. Although *Mothbears* are even more feared. Mothbears. What would one of those look...? Never mind.

I can't tell where it lives. It's outside of the village's range, as are the new houses we're trying to build. That's a problem. Knowing what's around me is essential. I can sense the entire village and when someone gets hurt I can tell at once.

Like when one of Gamel's friends slipped and nearly cut his hand off while trying to cut through a broken beam in one of the houses. I shouted and got a healing potion to him in time. If we're making a new village, no, if we're going to keep this village safe, I need to be able to 'see' more.

Which means I need to expand my claim on the lands around. The problem is, the area around Riverfarm is wilderness, forest, open ground, rivers...no one owns it and I can't just say that's mine. I tried, and it doesn't work.

I have to do something about that. But maybe later. I lie down next to Durene, my head's spinning with ideas and thoughts. Safety is a relative thing. It can leave you at any moment. But I'm very grateful I hired the Silver-rank adventurers. They could kill the bear if they had to, despite its size. And Durene's here. She *wrestled* the bear.

The village has its guardians. What would happen without them? The next day...I find an answer to that question.

Day 60

The Windfrozen Riders picked up the man on the horse at the road and brought him to Riverfarm. By the time he arrives, looking frozen and practically tumbling off of his saddle, I'm there with Prost, Gamel, Durene, and a hot mug and food for him.

He eats like a beast and nearly weeps when he tastes the hot sausage. He does weep when he takes in Riverfarm and hears about the avalanche. I see him hugging Prost and crying into the man's shoulder.

Apparently this man is named Helm, and he's a [Blacksmith] from another village nearby. Well, nearby is a relative term. His village is a good fourteen miles east of here, located by a big prairie. It is called Windrest, and it is burning.

Mister Helm practically throws himself at my feet when he hears who I am. I have to make him sit, and he keeps bowing his head as he explains what's going on.

"Goblins, milord. There are Goblins attacking every village from here to Mafalt. Raiding parties. They say there's a Great Chieftain of the Goblins who's rising in support of the Goblin Lord. They attacked our village—we have nowhere to go."

I listen in grave silence with the other adventurers. A group of around sixty Goblins had hit Windrest last night. They'd slaughtered a dozen people and torched a few buildings, but what they were after were the animals and winter stores the people had. They made off with two thirds of the village's goods and a lot of their supplies—and two young women. The

villagers had sent word to the nearest town and received assurances that adventurers would be sent out. But the village as it was right now was practically helpless.

They didn't have coin to hire protection. And they were terrified the Goblins or some other monsters might come back. With nowhere to turn, they'd sent Helm and others to look for aid. They needed food for the winter, someone to protect them...Helm had despaired at the task as he'd ridden from hamlet to village, until he'd come here.

He knew Riverfarm, and when he hears there are two Silver-rank teams guarding the place, his eyes nearly pop out of his head. When he hears I'm an [Emperor], Helm gets down on his knees in the snow and muck.

"Sire, we've nothing to offer you. But Windrest will perish as sure as I'm speaking if the Goblins come back. If you could spare your adventurers to guard us, give us just a bit that we might live, I swear we'll repay you!"

"You can't ask Emperor Laken for that!"

Prost is outraged. He speaks up before I can calm him down, addressing me as much as Helm.

"Take away our protection? We've barely enough food for ourselves! If we spared the grain and meat to keep your village alive, we'd be stabbing ourselves in the back!"

"We can't live, Prost. Not with what we have. We're this close to selling what we own and going to the nearest town to become [Beggars], the lot of us."

Helm turns his ashen face towards Prost, looking wretched. He knows what he's asking, but he has to ask. A small village that suffers this kind of raid in the winter...I understand.

But still, I can't give him either adventuring team. Goblins. If they hit Windrest, they will come to Riverfarm. I know it and feel a chill. But the people...

What would anyone do? I look at Helm and know there is only one thing I can say. Prost is looking at me with pain in his eyes. I glance at him, and nod.

"Bring your people here, Mister Helm."

The [Blacksmith] looks up, eyes widening. I look around at the other villagers, at the adventurers, at Prost and Durene. I nod at Prost.

“We might not have enough food for all of us at the moment. We don’t have much room, but we do have people who can protect everyone. I’ll do something about food if it comes to it. But I will not let your people die if I can help it.”

“Thank you, your majesty! Thank you! We’ll never forget it!”

Helm tries to kiss my hands. I order him to get some hot food in him and tell him I’ll send an escort to Windrest. When the man is eating a second meal—he looks half-starved—I glance over at Prost.

He looks worried. Mister Prost meets my eyes, a thousand unspoken problems at the tip of his tongue. I understand. But I can’t address his fears now. That’s not what I need to say. Not in this moment. I glance around as I see every eye in the village fixed on me and smile slightly. I nod at my [Steward].

“Mister Prost, I think we’re going to need a lot more houses.”

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4.21 E

Day 61

I used to be afraid of getting up in the morning. Or rather, reluctant. There are days when I want to crawl into my warm blankets and hide. Sleep is an alluring thing.

Funny. Having someone I love changes that. I feel Durene's presence when I sleep and when I wake—she's inevitably up before I am. And because I miss that, I get up.

That still doesn't mean I like the sensation of wandering around Durene's cottage and getting dressed in the morning any better. Durene is quite warm at night—enough so that blankets are necessary and clothing is not, but in the morning, her absence makes things chilly.

Is it undignified for an [Emperor] to walk around looking for a clean shirt and arguing with his pet bird? If it is, only Durene sees that aspect of me. When I exit my cottage, I am dressed, fed, and mostly coherent.

Today's a big day. Just like yesterday. The man from Windrest, Helm, is due to return with his villagers tonight. I sent him back with an escort and the Wildfrozen Riders will have left already to escort the villagers down the road to my village.

I hope they make it here safely. Goblin attacks are on the rise and many villages are in danger. That's why this morning I make it a priority to talk with the two adventurers who are waiting for me first.

"Odveig, Wiskeria, can I trouble you to talk this morning? Durene has some tea hot in the cottage. Prost, is there anything I need to take care of at the moment?"

"Nothing, sire. Gamel and I will await you in the village."

Prost gives me a surprisingly elegant bow and he and Gamel retreat. The two female adventurers, the leader and sub-leader of the Celestial

Trackers, exchange glances. The shorter one with the mace shifts uncomfortably.

“I would hate to intrude Mister L—I mean, your majesty!”

“No need to worry about formalities, Odveig. I’ve told you that.”

“Sorry, milord.”

I smile reassuringly at her. She’s clearly uncomfortable around me, still. Wiskeria on the other hand seems to have adjusted to the current situation quite well.

“It’s quite cold out. I’d like to ask about the Goblin attacks and what you know of them.”

“Ah!”

Odveig seems relieved; I can hear her tone lighten and sense her posture change. She nods at Wiskeria.

“If that’s what the problem is, we can talk about the Goblins. There’s not a problem in my eyes, but we’ll know more about the threat once the villagers return, right enough.”

There’s something funny about the way she says ‘not a’, as if it’s one word. Perhaps it’s because I’m blind, but that instantly puts a smile on my face to hear an accent so nicely distinct.

Funny, I can’t help but think of her as Scottish or of some similar heritage. Her accent’s a good bit different, but there’s that name and...wait, is Odveig a Scottish name? No...I don’t think so. What country then?

Ah, does it matter? There’s only so many ways words can be written in any language, and this world’s fixation on the English language means there would be parallels. And why does everyone speak English? Ryoka had a theory...

I lead the two young women inside—well, Odveig is definitely older than I am, and Wiskeria’s probably older too—and they take a seat on one of Durene’s oversized stools and sip from her mugs. Durene’s already left to help in the village.

“It seems like a lovely cottage, sire.”

Wiskeria sits comfortably in Durene's home. I can't detect a hint of disingenuity in her voice, so I hope she's being honest.

"Yeah, it's ah, a really nice place, your majesty."

Odveig is a poor liar. I can sense her sitting across from me, looking around anxiously and then at me while she clutches her mug in both hands. She hesitates.

"Not to pry, but why are you staying here? As I said, it's wonderful but...wouldn't it be safer to sleep in the village? I know a few good houses have been dug out—they'd surely be more comfortable than here—not that here is—"

She stumbles over her words and shuts up, embarrassed. I smile at her again.

"I'm sure it would, but this cottage has sentimental value to me, Odveig. I first met Durene here, and it's a fine place for me to sleep and work from. I seldom stay here anyways; it's got a few of my possessions, and a bed, which is all a good home needs."

"Ah. Well. That's good. Uh, you said you wanted to talk to us about Goblins? Your majesty?"

I hope she can get over her awkwardness soon. Covering an internal sigh, I reach for my mug. Oops. It's empty.

"Allow me."

Wiskeria takes the tea pot over the fire and fills the cup for me quite gracefully. I'm surprised—she could be a [Maid], not a [Witch] for how coordinated she is. I nod to her.

"Thank you, Wiskeria."

Yes, Wiskeria and Odveig are an odd duo. Odveig's clearly at home with the mace she uses, but she's far more awkward outside of battle, and that's presumably why she turns to Wiskeria for advice so often. Wiskeria the [Witch] often seems to have answers when Odveig falters.

She's competent, quiet, well-spoken and...my first pick if it comes to it. But enough about that. I'll get to know them more over the next few days. I

steeple my fingers together as if I'm at a board meeting and lean over the table.

"Goblins. I know they're attacking villages all over the place. Is that normal? It seems like these villages are prey to any kind of monsters that come along. How could anyone survive like this?"

Wiskeria and Odveig exchange a glance. It's Wiskeria who speaks for the both of them. I can sense that she wears some kind of glasses—spectacles I think these ones are called. She adjusts the frame as she speaks.

"Goblin attacks are common in most places of the world as I'm sure you know, sire. However, around Invrisil, they're known to be well-coordinated and particularly nasty. Not that they're particularly common or this vicious—mostly, Goblins will raid a farm and steal what animals they can, make away with a [Farmer]'s stores—sometimes kill, but usually they just want food. These ones are different."

"It's this new Great Goblin Chieftain. There was word a while back—a group of women were found outside the gates of Merendia not two weeks back. Apparently a Goblin tribe of all things left them there."

"A Goblin tribe? But wait—these women—were they—?"

The silence from both Wiskeria and Odveig confirms my darkest suspicions. Odveig clears her throat.

"It's just rumor and hearsay, but I heard that this Goblin tribe actually rescued them. Apparently, there's a huge Goblin tribe living in a nearby mountain—Dwarf halls Rest it's called. We had no notion it was occupied, but there's a Great Goblin Chieftain living there, or so the women claim."

"A Great Chieftain?"

"I'd never heard of it myself, your majesty. It's caused panic all over the nearest cities once they heard of it, especially with this Goblin Lord to the south."

"Right. Goblin Lord south, Great Chieftain around here."

It's hard keeping track of this Goblin news Durene and the others seem so well-versed in. I've never met a Goblin. They sound like horrible monsters, though. Very Tolkein-esque. And a Great Chieftain is apparently bad news. City-ending bad news, which is a horrible thought.

“It seems this other Goblin tribe splintered from the mountain. The women claimed there was fighting and they were helped to escape. Well, the upshot of that is that the Goblins that still remain in the mountain are hopping mad. Probably lost a lot of food or whatever they were hoarding, so they’re hitting villages and towns with massive raiding parties. Not just a few Goblin stragglers with knives and rocks—Hobgoblins and lots of smaller Goblins with real weapons.”

That sounds like *exactly* the sort of thing I didn’t want to hear. I must look worried, because Wiskeria hastens to assure me.

“You paid for both our group and the Windfrozen Riders, sire. We’re capable of fighting off any lone raiding party aimed at a village. However, it might be best to take precautions.”

“Indeed. Thank you for telling me. If you don’t mind, I’d like to discuss exactly what you had in mind. These Goblins...say they came to this village. How would you prefer to fight them off?”

That’s the first part of my day. After talking with both adventurers, I immediately head into the village and find Prost.

He’s busy supervising a bunch of young men and women who are busy cutting down and then cutting up trees. I’m no carpenter, so the flurry of movement is all a mystery to me. But this is the first step on getting those new houses done.

“Mister Prost.”

“Your majesty! What can I do for you?”

“A lot, unfortunately. I’ve just talked with Wiskeria and Odveig—they’re concerned about Goblin attacks and so am I.”

My voice is loud enough that the other villagers working on the trees glance up. Prost sounds concerned.

“Yes, your majesty. We’ve heard the same. It’s customary for a few of the older folk with levels to organize a militia of sorts, but that’s only if we think there’s a handful of Goblins hiding out. If there’s a lot, we can only trust to adventurers.”

“True. But that doesn’t mean we have to sit idly knowing there are Goblins around. I was thinking we could add a palisade to the list of things

we're building."

"A palisade, sir?"

Palisades. Fences made of sharpened wood stakes. Prost is certainly familiar with the idea, but Riverfarm never had any walls of any sort. Nevertheless, when I give him the idea he agrees it's possible. Only...

"Only, it's difficult, sire. I have this lot hewing the wood and then planing it for construction with hand-tools, but that's a far cry from a sawmill, which is what I'd prefer. It'll be slow going without more hands..."

"We'll get those soon enough. However, I'm not suggesting we put up walls all the way around the village. A few to block off the most undefended routes would be good to start with. I was thinking around the barn, using the back as a wall, you see?"

"Oh! Right!"

Prost and I do a short tour of the village and go over how many trees he'd need for that, and the time it would take. When he goes off to shout that he needs more hands for trees, I wander back over to Gamel. I heard his voice and sensed he was among the workers there.

"Gamel, how's work going?"

The young man pauses with some sort of long iron bar in his hands. He's using it to keep the log steady while others hack at it with axes. It looks complex, and I'm sorry to have stopped him, but he and the others immediately jump to their feet.

"Your majesty!"

"I don't want to disrupt you. I just thought I'd ask how you're doing."

"Well, sire. I'm happy to be helping and be back in the village. I uh, this is Tessia and Erhart. Tessia's a childhood friend. She and I, uh—"

Gamel stammers and introduces me to two people, one of whom is a young woman he's clearly biased towards. They introduce themselves, bowing and curtsying awkwardly—although both are wearing trousers and thick clothing because it's cold.

"Your majesty, I'm honored."

The young woman known as Tessia has a quiet voice as she introduces herself. Erhart seems tongue-tied at meeting me.

I smile at Tessia, and then remember a young woman with a shard of wood sticking out of her leg as the digging team pulls her out of the snow. She remembers too, and bows low over my hand as I offer it.

“I—I wanted to say...thank you. I can’t ever say what it means—I thought when I was down there—”

Her voice breaks. I grip her hands as Gamel reaches for Tessia’s shaking shoulders.

“I know. I’m glad I could help.”

That’s all. I leave the two to the tree and step away. I’ve had similar conversations with almost all of Riverfarm’s people at one point or another. It’s not embarrassing so much as painful when I speak to them.

I wish I could have saved them all. But I know that was impossible.

Something else attracts my attention as I talk about how many trees need to be cut for the new defenses. I sense a large number of bodies entering the outskirts of the village and hear shouts coming from that direction.

“Prost. I think the people from Windrest are here.”

Prost and I hurry over to where the commotion is happening. In my sense of the village I can tell a huge crowd has entered, accompanied by a few donkeys pulling wagons, overloaded carts with valuable possessions—

It’s a nightmare. I didn’t expect an entire village’s worth of people! No—I did expect it, but seeing the population of Riverfarm double in a moment blows me away. If I didn’t have my inner view of the village, the noise alone would render my sense of hearing useless.

“There he is!”

I hear a voice. Helm is shouting and waving towards me and Prost as we stride towards the crowd. I hear the majority of voices cut off, and then every eye is on me. A few people begin whispering incredulously in the crowd.

“Is that him? Is that—”

“An [Emperor]? In Izril?”

“Why’s he got his eyes closed? You can’t mean he’s truly blind? Not—”

“Attention!”

Prost’s voice shouts across the entire village. I can sense the man standing tall beside me. He waves a hand and the villagers fall still. Oh, well if Prost’s got it—I relax a bit. Too soon!

“Kneel before Emperor Laken, the Protector of Riverfarm! In his mercy, he has allowed you to—”

I elbow Prost in the side and cut him off before he can say anything more. Okay, *not* what I hoped he would say. I clear my throat, and take a few steps forwards. Every eye is on me. I speak, calmly, reassuringly.

“I am Laken Godart. An [Emperor].”

Voices. Murmuring. I wait for silence, and go on.

“I welcome you to Riverfarm, people of Windrest. Please know that you will be safe here. However, while you stay in my domain, you must obey me as your ruler.”

Shock—I wish I could see their expressions, with my eyes. I sense people shifting around me. But I don’t move. I am that I am. Calm. This is how it is.

“I own these lands. If you cannot accept that, I am afraid there is no place for you. But know this: while you are here, I will do everything in my power to protect you. You have my word on it.”

Silence. Then I hear someone clapping. Prost. This time it’s what’s needed. The people of Riverfarm begin cheering my name, and then I hear the people of Windrest take up the feeling. They shout my name and cluster around me.

Do they believe I’m an [Emperor]? I don’t know, but Durene tells me I have a look about me that makes me different. And whatever they believe, I’ve promised them safety. So they shout my name and a man fights his way to me.

“Your majesty, it’s me! Helm, sire!”

I find my hand being shaken rapidly by huge, callused hands that nearly break mine. I extricate myself from Helm's grip as he shouts at me.

"We're ready to work, sire! I know there's houses needing to be dug out and more built—us Windrest folk have brought our tools and there's some good [Carpenters] and [Builders] among us! Just say the word and we'll do what needs doing, milord! I'm a [Blacksmith]! I have my anvil—I'd sorely love to ply my trade here, if your lordship's willing?"

Didn't I hear that Izril has a lot of [Lords] and [Ladies]? It seems like I'm being treated like a more outstanding version of one. I nod at Helm, raising my voice so the people around me can hear.

"We'll have work for you soon, Mister Helm. If you've an anvil, all the better. We could use nails, repairs to tools that were damaged in the avalanche, more nails...there's always work for a [Blacksmith], as I'm sure you're aware."

"Yessir! And the rest of my kin—I've a cousin and two daughters, what will they—"

Helm's voice is anxious. I place a hand on his shoulder—amazing the people around me since I'm talking and moving with my eyes closed—and reassure the man.

"Everyone will work, don't you worry, Mister Helm. So long as people work, they'll have a roof over their heads and a warm belly and a place to sleep. We might have to build the roofs first, but...if you have any concerns, Prost, my [Steward], will handle them."

When I mention Prost's class I hear gasps, none more loudly than Helm's own. As if my words have summoned him, Prost strides into the crowd and takes the attention of the group off of me.

"The [Emperor]'s not a man who has the time to deal with you louts himself! Line up—divide yourselves by classes, the lot of you! I'll put families together once we've sleeping places sorted out—leave your tools and such over there! We'll organize it later I said! And we'll share what we have—no hoarding! Helm, who's the [Village Head] around here?"

I walk away from the group and watch Prost get to work. He's efficient. The people of Windrest know what to do, and when he tells them where to

put their belongings and what needs doing, experienced workers like the [Carpenters] immediately peel off and get to work on the felled trees, while other [Woodcutters] grab axes and head towards people cutting.

More people go to the barn to help unload the carts, quite a number of women and a few men stay to manage the children, and in the midst of it all, an old man with a limp, bad posture, and a desperate note in his voice grabs me.

“Your majesty, I beg a word.”

“Certainly, uh—”

“Jelov, your majesty! I’m afraid that your man Prost might not have a job for me! I—I’m old and might not be worth the effort of keeping, but I beg your mercy! Please!”

He looks desperate, and no wonder. He’s the oldest person I’ve seen in this world, and his hands are as contorted as his back. I calm him down and take him a few feet away from the crowd around Prost.

“I’m sure there’s work for you Jelov. What’s your class?”

“Woodworking sire!”

“Oh? Well, if you’re a [Carpenter]—”

The man’s voice contorts with equal measures agony and indignation.

“I’m no [Carpenter], your eminence. I’m a [Carver]—damned class though it is! I carve toys of wood, hilts, handles—my hands can’t hold an axe in my old age, much less lift all that weight! There’s not a call for it at the moment, not now with folks building and whatnot. No need for toys when there’s not enough places to sleep, but it’s all I can do!”

He looks pleadingly at me.

“I wouldn’t dare ask normally, but I’ve a granddaughter and if I can’t work—”

“Of course you can work! If carving’s what you do, we’ll let you carve, Jelov. Toys? Why wouldn’t we need them? Children have to play after a disaster, and I’d consider it a blessing to have things to occupy them.”

The old man's eyes widen as I interrupt him. He looks so relieved he might faint. I can see why—if a village is in dire straits, the elderly might be the first to be deemed expendable.

“Why thank you sire, I'd do whatever needs doing—I could fletch too, although I'm a slow hand if it's not with a carving knife—”

“No, no. Carving's just the thing. You could help me with a project I need doing.”

Is it coincidence Jelov found me? I recall one of the things—a piece of advice I'd been given. Intrigued, Jelov cocks his head to one side, his beard blowing in the wind.

“You'd like something carved, [Emperor] Laken, sire? I can do detailed woodwork. A piece for your mantle?”

“More like a pole in the ground. I'm thinking of a large wooden pole, Jelov, the kind of thing you could plant in the ground and leave for years. Like a signpost, only...etched.”

“Etched? Ah, you mean illustrated with letters and so on, sire? I could do that! Is there a name for this piece you'd want?”

“Less of a piece, and more of a marker. Let's call it a, uh, totem pole of sorts.”

The old man starts looking worried again, and just when I'd calmed him down.

“Totem, sire? What kind of wood is totem? We've naught but cedar trees around here mainly, although I know a good birch—”

“Uh, not that. It's a kind of carving. Which I'd greatly desire. Do you think you could take a large block of wood, around this wide—”

I measure a square about a hand-and-a-half wide in each direction and eight feet high for Jelov and tell him what I'm thinking. Soon the old man's stroking at his beard and chattering to me, spraying me and the nearby surroundings with a bit of spit as he does. His earlier timidity is gone as his love of the craft—and pride—takes over.

“A pole like that? *Pshaw*—oops, sorry 'bout that, your majesty. Carving a few fancy shapes into this much wood? Naught a problem. See, the issue's

in varnishing and I know a few young lads who'd do it right quick if you let me have them—and I've the oils and resins I bought from an [Alchemist]. Served me well these last few years—no, I could have it carved up in a day or two. The processing's the thing, see? And design of course."

"So quickly?"

I edge away from Jelov, but he just crabs over to me, talking excitedly. Aw, well, who needs a dry face anyways? Isn't spit good for the skin?

"I'm not this old for nothing, sire! I've many a Skill—reckon I could get a good start, just so long as I know what you're wanting. Got anything in particular you want on it, or just some fancy etchings? I can do fancy—folk think I've written mage symbols when they're nothing but scribbling on the bark."

"I have an idea, thank you. I'd like the top to have a symbol. This would be a, uh, marker of sorts, so I want it to show that."

"Right, right. What kind of symbol?"

"How about...an eye?"

I really hadn't thought this part through too much. I need a symbol of my domain, so an eye naturally pops into my mind. I sketch an Egyptian-style eye into the ground and Jelov nods appreciatively.

"Not hard at all. You want two of them?"

"One's fine. It would go here at the top, and then maybe carve a line to separate it...can you put the eye in a, ah, triangle? A pyramid? It would look like this."

"Ooh, now that's occult, sire. Feels like it's staring at me, so it does. And them little lines—are they bricks?"

"Yes. Yes, that's a pyramid. An ancient structure. And below it, some ground—"

"Ah! A floating eye in a pyramid-thingy! Very good. I can carve that no problem sire."

Jelov's making encouraging noises, probably taken with the symbol I'm designing for him. Myself, I feel a bit...embarrassed. It's not as if I'm coming up with the design, obviously.

It's just a silly thought. But the Eye of Providence—a part of the U.S. bill and often associated with the Illuminati—is a cool symbol. It makes for as good an inscription as any, and I have a sense that this totem pole, this marker, *needs* to have this kind of symbol.

Because it will represent my people, my village. Me. And I can always change it later.

“That’s the head taken care of your majesty. What’s the next bit?”

“Next bit? Uh...”

There’s a lot of totem pole to go. I frown, thinking on the go.

“How about some fancy symbols below it? You could do a—a hawk. And a village, maybe? And then you write on it sideways—‘Claimed by Emperor Laken Godart’. How about that?”

Jelov’s busy drawing in the dirt. When he’s done, I stare at the plans for a totem pole practically covered by ‘fancy occult stuff’ that has the old man rubbing his hands together in glee. I smile.

“Add whatever you think might be good. Maybe carve it so it’s not just a rectangle of wood? I’ll leave it to you, but when you have the final design, show it to me. I’ll...need quite a few once we have the design set.”

“At once, your [Emperor]-ness! I’ll uh, need a piece of wood—”

“I’ll have Prost get some to you right away. And helpers if you need it, but for now the pole?”

“At once! Don’t you worry milord, I’ll have the pole ready to show you tomorrow. Let me just find my best knife—have to cut with the best tools I say. Have you met my daughter? Want to show her the trade, by your lord’s leave of course. A natural. Woodworking’s in the family blood. You’ll see—it’ll be my finest work, my word on it. Won’t let you down. I recall one time I did a piece—”

Somehow, I get away from Jelov and by the time I do, the village is bustling with activity. Prost is in the thick of it, and I find myself talking with people, reassuring them, pointing out my adventurers and...being an [Emperor], I guess. I have an answer for every trivial problem, which isn’t hard, but I’m doing it and everyone’s watching, which is apparently all they need.

The sun has set by the time I have a bowl of hot soup in my hands and am eating it standing up. I'm exhausted from talking, but I have time for one last person who approaches me on horseback.

"What news, Beniar?"

The adventurer and captain of the Windfrozen Riders ducks his head towards me, for once not showering me with compliments or praising himself. He sounds grim, and a bit worried.

"Trouble, your majesty. Windrest was mostly devastated, but it's hardly the only village. I met a group of travelers on the road heading straight for Invrissil—they say their village was attacked and torched. The Goblins took everything and slaughtered everyone they caught. They're killing this time, not just raiding."

I feel coldness inside my heart. Goblins. I nod to the village.

"Do you think they'll come here?"

"Unless they get what they want, it's a surety, sire. We'll double our patrols, but I'd be more comforted if I knew how many Goblins might come our way. We can handle Hobgoblins, a large band, even a Goblin [Shaman] if one of those bastards is hiding among them. But Goblins can come at any time, from *anywhere*. That's what makes them dangerous."

"I understand. And I have a plan to deal with that, Beniar."

"Do you, your majesty?"

He sounds skeptical. I just smile at him.

"Trust me."

He hesitates. I can hear him getting off his horse, and then shouting for some soup for himself and fodder for his mount.

"For some reason, I do your majesty. Emperor Laken."

"Oh?"

I'm a bit uncomfortable with Emperor Laken, but it is who I am. And Beniar seems to think so too. I sense him nodding towards the villagers.

"I've never seen a [Lord] shaking common folk's hands before, much less an [Emperor]. It gives them hope. I...I'm glad you care about villagers,

sire. I was one once, too.”

“Villagers. Lords. We’re all people, Beniar.”

He laughs shortly.

“Yeah, but you’d not see a [Lord] care so for common folk.”

“Really? Then—here.”

I hold one of my hands out to Beniar while I cradle the hot soup bowl with the other. He stares at it. I waggle my fingers impatiently.

“Go on, shake it.”

He does, tentatively. I smile at him and take another hot spoonful of soup.

“Well? How does it feel? You’ve just shaken hands with an [Emperor]. I’m no [Lord], Beniar. I’m better than that. I care about all of my subjects. And I’ll protect them no matter what.”

He stares at me.

“Does that include us, sire? Me and my riders?”

“I’ve hired you. While you work for me, I’ll do my best to make sure you’re as safe as anyone else.”

“That’s reassuring to hear, your majesty.”

“Yes, it is, isn’t it? Let’s work hard to make sure I’m not made into a liar, Beniar.”

“Yes, your majesty.”

[Emperor Level 10!]

[Skill – Empire: Low-born Militias Obtained!]

[Skill – Rallying Presence Obtained!]

“...Is there an instruction manual or something?”

“Whuzzat, Laken?”

“Nothing, Durene.”

Day 62

People skills. That’s all being an [Emperor] is. People skills. Or is it more like a video game about allocating resources? My job as an [Emperor] is not to manage the details of what I do—I have Prost, Helm, and the other older villagers to take that duty off of me. I look at the grand scheme, give broad orders, deal with situations—

And make sure people do what’s most effective. Which is why Beniar’s enthusiasm can be a problem.

“Give us the order, and we’ll bring back enough game to feed the village, sire! My team can cover countless miles and be back by the end of the day!”

Beniar seems determined to be of help the next day, but in an odd way. He’s offered to hunt, and I admit, having a food source might be just the thing now that we have far more mouths to feed than I had projected for. Prost calculates that we have enough supplies to last for a month, but not through till spring anymore.

Still, I shake my head as I talk with Beniar and the other adventurers in the morning.

“I’d rather have your people patrolling. A few hunters might be acceptable Beniar, but your riders need to patrol.”

“As you say, sire.”

He’s disappointed, but his idea is solid. I turn to Odveig and Wiskeria.

“Do you think you could hunt with your group, Odveig? Wiskeria? If the Windfrozen Riders patrolled, I think we could spare the Celestial Trackers.”

They’re not a mounted group, so the idea seems fine to me. Wiskeria voices her agreement immediately.

“We could send several groups out, sire. There are trails of deer and other animals we picked up—”

It’s Odveig who interrupts her, shaking her head adamantly.

“Not a good idea, Wiskeria. I think we’ll keep our group here by your leave, your majesty. There could be trouble and I’d hate to fail our contract if we don’t keep you safe from all dangers.”

She frowns at Wiskeria and I frown too. But Odveig *is* the leader and she makes sense. The Mossbear could wake up, or something else could happen.

“If you’re sure. In that case Beniar, I’ll let you take three of your riders and hunt...the rest will spread out with the Celestial Trackers nearby...”

Every day has a challenge. Today’s is rats. Apparently, the new ground Prost is trying to dig up has rats.

In the winter.

“How are there rats, Mister Prost?”

I walk around the edge of the new village boundary. I can vaguely sense this place, mainly because the villagers are laying down the foundations of the new houses as we speak. Prost grimaces.

“The little devils have to make their burrows somewhere, Emperor Laken.”

“Yes, but...what do they eat? How can they survive?”

“There’s root stores in the ground, and the rodents prey on our fields. I reckon there’s a few burrows here—they’ll infest the houses and cause a mess if we can’t get rid of them first.”

“Right...how do we do that?”

Prost sighs, sounding vexed.

“Only way is to dig up all the ground about here with pitchforks and kill the damned vermin as they come out.”

I frown.

“That sounds like it’ll take a lot of time and effort we don’t want to spare.”

“Yes sire, but it’s the only way. We don’t know where they could be hiding—”

Wait. I frown as Prost says that. Rats, hiding in the ground? I feel like... I feel like I might be able to solve this one. I cut Prost off and stare at the ground. This area is mine. Vaguely mine. And I can sense what goes on in the ground, can’t I? I saved the villagers that way. So why can’t I look—

Down.

My senses go beneath the earth. I sense thick, rich loam beneath my feet, roots—the remains of a grass stalk and its system. And across from me—two feet down, a tunnel network. Something moves in it. Big, furry, chewing at a bug that wriggles through the soil—

“Emperor Laken? Sire?”

A hand touches my shoulder and I nearly jump out of my skin. I start, look around. Prost is staring at me with concern in his eyes. I blink at him, and then grin weakly.

“Mister Prost, I think I can solve our problems. But we’ll need a way to kill the rats when they come up. Unless you’re planning on stomping the rats to death or hacking them apart?”

I don’t think I could stand to see that. But Prost only smiles.

“No sire, we’ve a time and tested way to deal with that!”

“Oh?”

Dogs. Eight dogs of varying shapes and colors snuffle around my feet and sniff me, wagging their tails as they circle around Prost and a group of [Farmers] with shovels and pitchforks. I watch as Prost sticks his pitchfork into the loose, frozen earth that’s been broken up and lift it with a grunt.

Something *squeaks*. I recoil, and the dogs go nuts as a group of rats unearthed by the pitchfork flee. The dogs growl and run down the rodents

in moments. The [Farmers] cheer them on, whistling as they unearth more rats which the dogs hunt down with almost contemptuous ease.

Terriers. The world's finest ratters. Of course, that's what they were bred for, back when they weren't just pets but companions. I feel stupid for not thinking of it, but I'm both gratified and entertained to see the dogs in their elements. They clearly love to hunt down the rat nests which I can pinpoint with ease.

That's right. Just like the villagers trapped under the snow, I can see under the ground. And that means I can see every rat that's infested the fields we're trying to turn into a new area for houses.

It feels almost dirty to have this ability. And I have to say, when Prost's pitchfork comes up with a tiny impaled rat on it, still squeaking and struggling, I feel awful. But they are rats. They'll destroy a field and breed until they start eating each other given half a chance, and Prost and the other farmers clearly hate them with a passion.

"Damned fine work, your majesty!"

One of the farmers shouts at me, earning a jab from his friends for swearing, but I only grin and wave at him. This is one of the cases where my [Emperor] talents really help the villagers in a concrete way. I wonder if all [Emperors] can see their lands like I do. Am I just attuned to these senses more than others because I'm blind?

Ah, well, I can't tell.

I hear a squawk as another group of rats makes it to the surface to be pounced upon by the dogs the villagers of Windrest brought with them. I look over and hear fluttering wings.

"Frostwing giving you trouble, Gamel?"

"I think she wishes to join in the hunt, sire."

Gamel struggles with my pet bird. Frostwing's bigger than ever and antsy at being cooped up in Durene's cottage all day, so I've asked Gamel to bring her with me when I walk around the village. It might have been a mistake. Frostwing is struggling as she perches on his arm—he has to wear a cloth armguard to keep her talons from puncturing his skin.

"Calm down, Frostwing."

She shuts up for a second, and I can sense her head turning to glare at me. I nod to Prost.

“Here’s another nest.”

I tap the ground and the man comes over and sticks his pitchfork in the dirt. The dogs tense and he heaves—rats go flying.

Frostwing shrieks as the rats run about. I hear Gamel struggling to keep the bird steady on his arm as she flaps wildly. Then her wings open. She launches herself from his arm.

She *flies*.

Five feet. Frostwing *smacks* into a rat as it tries to scurry away from one of the dogs. She knocks the rodent aside and then hops towards it, wings spread aggressively. I see Prost yanking one of the excited dogs back as Frostwing pecks at the large rat with her sharp beak. It tries to flee and she hops right after it.

There have been epic battles waged in the name of survival between different animal groups. The duel between the lone rat and the fledgling Frostwing is not one of them. She pecks at the rat and the rat tries to run. Frostwing pursues, hopping rather than flying, and I give her a bit of assistance, blocking the rat with my foot.

Hop, peck. Hop, peck. In the end Frostwing downs the rat, but I have to say, she does not deserve the sense of satisfied pride I feel from her in my mind. As my bird savages the rat she’s killed and begins to disembowel it, I kneel by her side.

“Who’s a good bird? You are. You’re a good bird. Even if you are fairly bad at your job.”

She pecks at me with a bloody beak, and then flares her wings aggressively as one of the villager’s dogs sniffs near her. It retreats, whining, and I decide to pick Frostwing up before she can cause trouble. She agrees to perch on my arm only after grabbing her kill in one talon. On the way back to the cottage she drops the rat. Twice. Nothing would do but I let her grab it again.

Ah, birds. They’re quite stupid. Dumber than dogs at times, which I’ll admit is difficult. But I love mine even so.

“Emperor Laken! Your majesty, I have your pole of totems! Here! Won’t you inspect it?”

At the end of the day Jelov comes to me with a finished pole, just as he’s promised. I inspect the pole with my hands, running my fingertips along the carvings, and feeling the deep-cut symbols in the wood. I get a splinter. Twice.

“It’s not smoothed yet, and there’s work to be done rounding and varnishing, but if you’re satisfied, I can copy the design onto however many poles you want, sire!”

“That will be excellent, Jelov. You’re a fine craftsman.”

“Thank you, your majesty!”

He beams. I wonder whether anyone else in the world has ever been so happy to have their work praised by a blind man. But this new totem pole has caught people’s imaginations. Certainly Durene’s.

“It’s so *creepy*, Laken! Are you sure you have to have the floating eye-thing? I keep thinking it’s staring at me and Jelov’s carved it onto all four sides, so it’s staring at you no matter where you’re facing!”

“It’s important because it’s a marker, Durene. The symbol marks who I am. Okay, maybe it was a mistake to make it the Eye of Providence, but—”

“Oh, if it’s a *symbol*, that’s fine. I was worried it’d be on our flag or something!”

I have to laugh as I sit next to her.

“Flag? Our flag? What are you talking about?”

Durene turns to me, surprised, as she munches on some fresh bread that Prost’s wife, Yesel baked in one of the ovens we uncovered this morning.

“Well, we’re obviously going to have a flag. This is your empire, right? Our empire, I mean. You’re going to rule us so we’ve got to have a flag! And a name! I think the Unseen Empire sounds cool, don’t you?”

The question throws me completely for a second. An empire? I suppose that is the logical step, but I've just seen what I'm doing as managing a village. But Durene's already talking about it as if it's an empire. I try to quell the uneasiness her words provoke with a slight joke.

"We're far away from an empire, Durene. We're just a village—"

"Two villages, now."

"True. But the people of Windrest are just staying here because they're afraid. Once the Goblins are gone—"

"They'll still be your subjects. They said so."

"Who did?"

"The people of Windrest, silly! You promised to keep them safe, remember? It's as good as being protected by a [Lord], they say, only you're *real*. I don't think they'd go anywhere even if the Goblins were gone."

The statement leaves me flabbergasted. Silent. Durene chews happily.

"Want some bread? It's really good and doughy, the way I like it! Laken? Hello? Laken?"

[Beast Tamer Level 5!]

Day 63

The reports of Goblin attacks continue. Beniar brings in two travelers on the road who say their caravan has been attacked by Goblins, a group of well-armed ones that looted their wagons and slaughtered their guards in a moment. I take them into the village. What am I supposed to do?

The situation with the Goblin incursions is clearly getting worse. I have an impromptu meeting with Beniar, Odveig, Prost, and Wiskeria and come to a quick decision.

"Train them."

“Who?”

“Anyone who wants to be trained. My village needs soldiers to protect it, and not just your adventurers.”

I rest my hands on the table and stare at Beniar, Odveig, and Wiskeria. They sound uncertain, but my mind’s made up. Odveig coughs.

“Begging your pardon sire, but we’re adventurers, not instructors. We can teach basic swordplay and fighting skills I suppose, but—but we can’t lead a group. And it’ll take weeks to make proper warriors out of most of this lot!”

“You don’t have to worry. I have a...Skill that might help matters.”

I grin at Odveig. I gained the [Empire: Low-born Militias] skill two days ago and I’ve been wondering what it does. I can’t help but suspect it would grant my subjects some combat prowess on the field. As for [Rallying Presence]—I can’t help but feel that’s one of the reasons why Windrest’s villagers have grown to trust me so quickly.

Regardless, relying on the two adventuring teams I’ve hired isn’t a good move long-term, which is why I’ve come up with this idea. I nod towards the [Witch] as she adjusts her pointy hat. Indoors. I guess she just likes wearing it.

“Wiskeria, do you think you could teach some of the people with magical aptitudes some magic? Gamel knows a fire spell, but it’s not useful for anything but lighting quick fires. If he could throw fire on the other hand...”

“I could teach them a bit, sire.”

“And I’ll show your young folk some swordplay your majesty, don’t fret! If Odveig wants to look out for Goblins, I’ll gladly demonstrate my Skills!”

Beniar is only too happy with the idea, of course. I smile sardonically.

“If you’re willing Beniar, I’d be grateful. However, I’d like you to take a certain student under your wing personally.”

“Who? Your man Gamel? I could turn him into a decent [Warrior] with enough time. It’d be my pleasure—”

“No. Durene.”

The tent goes silent. I sense Beniar gaping at me, but it’s Wiskeria who agrees first.

“Durene? She’s stronger than anyone I’ve met. As strong as a Minotaur. Stronger perhaps, with her [Enhanced Strength] Skill. Give her a sword and we’d have a warrior capable of facing down a Hob.”

“She’s untrained! And there’s not a sword that would fit her hands. We’d need a custom-built greatsword, and that would cost—”

Odveig protests, but my mind is made up. Within the hour, I have Durene, Gamel, and a bevy of young men and a surprising number of young women who have volunteered to train with the adventurers.

Beniar’s all for teaching everyone how to use a bunch of practice swords that Jelov and some [Carpenters] have thrown together, but I stop him and ask him to run the trainees through some exercises first.

“Exercises, your majesty? What, like swinging a sword? I can do that, but holding a sword’s important. Half of your folk look like they’d cut their thumbs off, swinging the swords like they are.”

I nod, watching Durene lift a huge club made from hammered-together bits of wood. It looks like a poor weapon, but I can’t help but wonder how much damage it would do if she smacked *me* with it. Certainly the other villagers are keeping away from her, and she’s using a partially-converted door as a shield. It still has the door handle on it.

“I know swordplay is important, but from what I understand, classes and Skills still rely on the body of each individual and their skill, don’t they?”

“True...I suppose I could have them train their bodies a bit. Although your villagers are fairly hale, milord.”

“Hale isn’t the same as trained. I’m thinking of giving them a little test first. Some running, arm exercises—”

“Oh?”

I nod to the excited villagers and eye Riverfarm. It’s an expanded mess of tents and lean-tos as the first few proper houses are going up. But the

snow's mostly cleared by now and there's a good path for people to run around in.

"Six laps around the village might be good. It's not too far. If they do that every day when they wake, I think it would help. And pushups. Sit-ups...I'll show you how to do burpees. It's a delightful exercise that everyone's sure to love."

Is there a bit of devil in me? Perhaps. I smile a bit as I see Beniar go over to the villagers and watch their enthusiasm drain away when they hear what they're going to be doing. I also studiously ignore Durene's glare as Beniar leads the villagers away at a run.

I'm no expert at swordplay. I have listened to descriptions of how soldiers train, though, and I am aware that a fit body matters a lot in battle. Is this the right method, teaching villagers how to do exercises that have half of them groaning with muscle pains by the end of it? Maybe, maybe not.

All I know is that by the end of the training session, the excited young villagers are a lot less excited about the prospect of training to be [Warriors]. By the time Beniar has them learning to hold a sword, half of them are looking longingly towards the other villagers and their normal duties.

That's where I step in. Everyone turns to stare at me as I walk forwards. Beniar's busy showing them how to strike properly. I raise my voice and address them all.

"I'm glad so many of you want to learn to fight. But please know this: if you want to train, I'll expect you to do what you just did every day, not just today. You'll have days to rest, but you'll be exercising like this as well as training and doing your jobs."

The young men and women look horrified at the thought. Durene opens her mouth, and I shake my head slightly at her. No favoritism. I look at them all, and then do a rare thing. I open my eyes slightly. I can't see obviously, but I want to look into their eyes like I've heard all good leaders do.

"Yes, I know how you feel. These exercises are grueling. But that's the point. Learning to fight is not fun. It's not easy. In fact, if you want to fight,

you'll have to work twice as hard as everyone else."

There's silence. I'm sure if I let them go now, not more than one or two would turn up tomorrow. Which is why the next bit has to count. I look at them all, trying to convey my feelings as openly as possible.

"You might ask why you have to work so hard. Well, it's because being a [Soldier], being a [Warrior] isn't an easy job. You're fighting for your life. Not just your lives either—you'll be fighting to defend your families, your loved ones—it's not a game. If you want to learn to fight, I'll gladly let the adventurers train you, but only if you are serious."

That's all. I nod to them and step back. I sense the villagers looking at each other. I don't know how many will come back tomorrow, but to my surprise, Prost comes over for part of the sword fighting lessons. I don't make him run around the village. He runs about enough without that.

Helm and a few of the other older villagers know how to fight too. Beniar trains with them and some of the adventurers and puts the young people through their paces.

"What do you think?"

I ask him that when the adventurer has returned to drink some water. Beniar mops sweat from his brow and frowns at me.

"Maybe it's luck or a Skill you have, your majesty, but I'd swear half of those villagers could put up a good fight if you gave them arms. I'd hate to be a [Bandit] gang that tries to rob this place."

"And Goblins?"

He grimaces.

"Your average Goblin? Hardly a threat, sire. But Goblins around Invisil are nasty. They have to be—we purge every tribe we come across as a matter of course. And the monsters around here get nasty. So the Goblins —"

"Are just as nasty."

"Just so, sire."

"Well, keep training them. I'll—"

I break off. Frowning, I stare away from the village, in the direction of our cottage. Beniar stares at me.

“Something wrong?”

“There’s someone in my cottage.”

I sense it. But when I get there with a panting Durene and Beniar, there’s no one to be found. However, Frostwing is shrieking her brains out. I ask Durene to look around, but nothing seems to be missing.

“Maybe it was someone from Windrest?”

“Maybe.”

I frown, but there’s nothing I can do, and there’s certainly no reason for me to post a guard on the cottage. Still, I wish I could identify people precisely with my [Emperor] senses. Who would want to check out my cottage in the first place?

It might just be a coincidence. But the next day, I find something else unexpected.

Day 65

“Are you sure we should do this, Laken?”

Durene’s voice quavers a bit as I hike up the slope with her in the lead. I’m grasping the back of her shirt as she walks. I’d normally use my cane, but I’ve grown so accustomed to moving about without it that I leave it in the cottage most days.

However, my [Emperor] senses don’t extend beyond the village limits, and so I’m blind out here. Blind, and possibly making the dumbest mistake of my life.

We’re trudging up a small hill towards the bear’s cave. Yes, the Mossbear’s cave. Durene has a large basket of dried fruits, cured meat, and other goodies. All things a bear might like.

“Why are we doing this, Laken? Couldn’t we just let it sleep?”

“Yes, but the trouble is, I don’t think it’s asleep anymore, Durene. The bear woke up once—it might wake up again. And I’d rather not have it go looking for food, especially if we can parley.”

“With a bear?”

“If we can. Just let me do the talking. You hang back a little bit.”

“What if it charges at you? I’m coming with you!”

“...Okay.”

In truth, I’m grateful. It’s one thing to have a stupid idea, and another thing to carry it out. But the Celestial Trackers have said the Mossbear is moving from his cave now and then, and I’ve been worried about what he might do.

What would *you* do if a bear was active in your vicinity? Run from it? Set a trap? Hunt it? Bury it in its cave? All of these options were given to me, and so I chose the dumbest idea I could think of myself: feed it.

It’s not entirely insane. I’ve explained my reasoning to Durene and she doesn’t buy it, but it makes sense to me. I was able to speak to the bear once. Intimidate it. Get it to leave. True, I had a bunch of scary humans and Durene with me at the time, but I *am* a [Beast Tamer]. And what is a bear if not a beast?

It’s just...a lot bigger than Frostwing is, that’s all. I feel Durene stop and stop with her.

“Is it...?”

“Just ahead. I can see the entrance. Laken, if it attacks—”

“Beniar’s waiting with a group of his riders. If the bear’s angry, he’ll lure it away. Just run, and take me with you.”

“If it comes after you I’ll kill it.”

There’s a steel core of determination in Durene’s voice. It shocks me for a moment.

“Don’t risk yourself, please. Running is fine. I know you’re strong, but I couldn’t bear for you to get hurt.”

“Hah!”

“What?”

“Bear. You said bear—”

“Oh, right. Haha.”

I’m too nervous to laugh at my own pun. I reach out and feel Durene deposit the heavy basket into my arms. I step forwards with it, and guided by Durene’s voice, place it at the entrance of the cave.

“Hello? Bear?”

Something ahead of me growls. I back up fast, and hear Durene move. I hear movement—and wish with all my heart I could sense what’s ahead of me. I get the impression of something big and *heavy* coming my way, and then a wet snuffle. The bear is investigating the basket, but it smells both me and Durene. It growls warningly.

Time for my brilliant plan to go into action. I clear my throat nervously.

“Uh, hi.”

The bear *growls*. I hear Durene shift and raise a hand.

“Hold on, I’m friendly.”

The bear doesn’t seem to listen. I hear it take a step and then Durene speaks.

“Laken—”

“Stop.”

This time the bear stops dead. I stare ahead, sightless, and hear Durene’s breath catch. Yes, now the feeling’s in me. Will. That is what an [Emperor] is. I project it at the bear, ordering it.

“Listen to me. I am not your enemy.”

It makes a whining sound and I think it backs up. I step forwards and Durene squeaks. But in this moment, as I am, there is no fear. An [Emperor] cannot be afraid when he is ordering a subject, and this bear *is* my subject. That’s how I must think of it.

“Look at me. See? I am a friend. Friend. And this is food. For you.”

It's like speaking to Frostwing, I feel. I have a bond with my bird that allows me to feel what she's thinking. With the bear, I have no such link, but I can still imagine what he's feeling. Confusion, hunger, maybe a bit of fear—but I am not his enemy.

And I think my voice reaches him. The bear doesn't retreat and he doesn't whine—instead he makes a whuffing sound that sounds tentative, almost inquisitive. I smile.

“Hello there. I'm Laken. Who are you?”

Shuffling. Durene makes another noise and I turn to signal her to stay put. And then—fur. I jerk in surprise and feel the bear's face jerk back from me. Durene moves.

“Stay put, Durene.”

I breathe the words. The bear is only a few inches away from me. I can smell his sour breath, hot on my face. He's sniffing at me almost like a dog, and I can feel his size. My knees want to quiver. A small, primate part of me wants to shriek and flee. But the rest of me is calm.

He is not my enemy. He is my subject.

And then the bear nudges my face with his. He blows hot air into my face—I sneeze on him. We become friends.

Of a sort. The bear is wary, but when it's clear neither I nor Durene are openly hostile, he immediately turns his attention to the basket. It's got all the food I know bears love. He paws at it, knocking the basket over and begins gulping down the food on the floor.

“Laken, do you think I—?”

Durene starts towards the bear and it backs up in surprise. I wince as it nearly tramples my foot with its claws.

“Better not, Durene. I think you might be a threat to him. You're as big as he is—”

“Take that back! I'm not as big—well, maybe I'm sort of—he's a lot heavier than I am!”

I can hear Durene flushing, but the moment breaks the tension. The bear continues eating. I poke it in the side and it doesn't even feel the gesture. So

I take the moment to run my hands along the bear's side. It grunts. In pleasure?

"You really are crazy."

Durene's voice is wandering. I can hear her edging around the bear for a better view, and then her voice lifts in surprise.

"Hey, what's that?"

"What's what, Durene? Is there something in the cave?"

"No, on the bear."

"What on the bear?"

"It looks—looks like there's a patch of his fur missing. I can't see at this range."

"Wait, what? Where?"

"Along the neck. Can you find it?"

Tentatively, moving very slowly I run my fingers down the bear's head, trying to find the spot Durene mentioned. The bear lets me do it—it might be my insanity talking or my [Beast Tamer] class, but I have the sense that I can interact with him, at least to this level.

My fingers run across something odd. Short hairs, bristly. The bear farts. I recoil and Durene gags. When the air clears I go back to the bear, coughing.

"Hm. *That's* odd."

Durene's right. A patch of the Mossbear's fur is indeed missing. It's hard to tell with my fingers, but my impression of the bear is that a good chunk of his fur is definitely absent near the nape of his neck.

"Why's that there? Do you think someone cut it off when we were fighting?"

"No, there's no blood. And the fur's too neat. This was no accident but...huh."

Another mystery. And not one the bear can solve; he eats all of the basket, turns, sniffs me, goes to crap in the woods and walks into his cave.

That's about the extent of my interaction with him; I never claimed I would be best pals with him, nor is this Winnie the Pooh.

Lovely book. Not many people know that Winnie the Pooh came from a book written by an English author, long before he became a Disney animated character. But I digress.

Durene and I leave the bear's cave and twenty meters later, Beniar rides out of the woods, practically shouting his amazement. The rest of the village clearly thinks I'm insane and fearless by equal measures.

It's just more embellishment for my reputation as an [Emperor] if you want to be cynical, but I did it because I wanted to see if I could. I know something now. An [Emperor] can command more than people. I know this because the second test I did was to get a few dogs and march over to the fields where the first house's walls were already standing upright.

A few rats survived the purge of two days ago. I sense a few under the earth. The dogs pad around me and warily edge back from Durene as I stand in the frozen snow. I point at the earth. At the rats hiding there.

“Out!”

The earth shifts. Three rats wriggle out of the earth and the dogs bark and fall on them. I stare at the ground. One of the rats is staying put.

“So it doesn't work on all of them.”

“So you can command rats? Can you call me a deer? I'd love to eat fresh meat for dinner.”

Durene looks wistfully at me. I shrug.

“Worth a shot. If I expand the boundaries of my domain, I could try it. Not all of the animals obey me entirely, though. Maybe if I level up as [Beast Tamer]...or is it [Emperor] that decides it?”

“Dunno. Look! Ew! One of the rats is in pieces!”

“I'm just as glad I can't. Durene, could you kick up the dirt right here, please?”

She does so obligingly. I failed to mention the rat. I didn't think it would be an issue, but when it ran up Durene's leg and she screamed—well, I supposed I didn't think to ask how afraid of rats Durene is. It took several

apologies and some cuddling that night to calm her down. But on the whole? Another successful day.

[Beast Tamer Level 7!]

[Skill – Animals: Basic Command Obtained!]

“Wow. I’ll finally be able to make Frostwing stop crapping on my hands.”

“Wha...? Laken, you say something? It’s late.”

“Nothing, Durene.”

Day 66

It’s just past midnight when I hear the pounding on Durene’s door.

“Emperor Laken! *Sire!* Please get up!”

The shouting wakes me and Durene in an instant. We untangle ourselves from the sheets and I’m the first one at the door. I yank it open and Gamel’s there, gasping and panting for air.

“What is it, Gamel?”

“It’s Beniar! He’s hurt!”

“What? How?”

Gamel opens his mouth and I hear a mortified cry from behind me.

“Laken! *Close the door!*”

“Oh shit.”

I realize Durene’s in a considerable state of undress as it were. I leap through the doorway as Gamel ducks back, flushing and apologizing. Standing half-naked in the cold, I hear Durene banging around the inside as Gamel shuts the door.

“I’m sorry sire—”

“What’s this about Beniar?”

“He rode back to the village half-dead, sire! His own group found him as the first patrol never came back—we’ve got healing potions on him, but they’re not working fully! Wiskeria says to come quick because she’s got to mix up a brew!”

I leave the cottage at a run, stopping only to grab a coat. When Durene, Gamel and I get to the barn, there’s a crowd of villagers around Beniar, staring and talking anxiously.

“Everyone move back! Give him space!”

Being an [Emperor] has its advantages. The way clears and I can see Wiskeria bending over Beniar, mixing together something in a bowl.

There’s an arrow in his stomach, and a half-empty healing potion on the ground beside him. Despite that, Beniar sounds closer to death than life. Wiskeria’s telling his party not to give him any more of the healing potion.

“The poison’s preventing it from working. The wound won’t heal and you’re wasting potion! Let me finish this.”

“Your majesty.”

Beniar croaks as I kneel by him. He’s still conscious. Apparently he was on his horse and riding this way when his team found him. As for what happened, he insists on telling me himself. He can’t sit up and has to whisper to me as I bend my head down.

“Arrow. Got me and Fabiel while we were riding. Didn’t even see—Fabiel died in a second. I think—I think it’s poisoned.”

“Who shot the arrow?”

“Goblins.”

It’s a whisper that silences everyone around him. I feel something begin churning in my gut. Of course.

“Five of them. They were waiting in ambush. Never seen—heard they did it sometimes. But didn’t expect—they rushed the horses. Fabiel’s is gone—I got away. They didn’t want to pursue. Just kill and loot.”

Beniar choked as someone tried to give him water. He coughed it out and continued as Wiskeria grabbed at her pouch, searching for something to add to the paste she was making.

“They’re not just coming, sire. They’re already here. Hiding.”

I stared at him. Beniar down. One of my adventures dead. All while I’d slept. All without me knowing. The Goblins weren’t anywhere in the village, that I could vouch for. But beyond it? Suddenly, the limits of my senses made me feel as if I was blind all over again.

“I have to apply this. Beniar, we need to take the arrow out, understand?”

Wiskeria brushes past me, not bothering with formalities. I step back and watch as Durene bends down to hold his legs. Someone else gets Beniar’s arms—he screams as Wiskeria pulls the arrow out and then applies the mash.

The people around me are worried. Children are crying, families are hugging each other. And all eyes are on me. Only this time, I don’t know what I should be doing. I search for words to reassure, and then hear something.

A horn call in the distance. It wails—a high, piercing sound that cuts through the night and makes the people of Riverfarm sit up and wake from their comforting dreams. It goes on for ten seconds, and then stops. Then it blows again.

Mocking. Taunting us. Telling us that we are not alone. I can picture Beniar’s pale face in the moonlight, Prost’s worried expression, Odveig’s intent eyes on his wound and Wiskeria’s gaze. Hers traverses the room to find mine. What kind of gaze? Cold? Expectant? Waiting.

They are here. They are coming. It turns out there’s evil, real evil in this world, and it’s not just us. It has a name. It hungers. It enjoys our suffering.

It is my enemy. And I will hunt it down. I hear the horn call a third time before it fades. It’s a prelude, an ending of the few moments of peace we have. They are coming.

Goblins.

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Day 66

So here it is. My first test as an [Emperor]. I, Laken Godart, am facing my first true crisis since I claimed Riverfarm. The avalanche was one thing, but I had the means to save the village at my fingertips. This time, I have no such ability.

The Goblins are here. Monsters with the cunning of people who want to destroy my village, slaughter my people, take all we've made. I don't know who they are or what to do.

I have protection—two Silver-rank adventuring groups. I thought it was enough, but in their first attack they killed one of my adventurers and nearly got Beniar. Now they're out there, probably planning to strike again and I have no idea what to do.

I'm no military buff. I don't know how to deal with an enemy that fights like this. And yet, ironically, I can put myself in the Goblin's minds. I know what I would do if I came to a village like this. Pick off my enemy one by one. Hide, ambush them, whittle them down and starve them if possible and then go for the kill.

So I suppose I do know what I have to do. I need to find the Goblins and kill them before they kill me. Simple to say, hard to do. I have to rely on others for this. I cannot fight. I cannot see past the boundaries of my village.

"Odveig, take your Trackers and find the Goblins. Don't attack if you think it's dangerous, but I want to know where they are and how many there are."

"Yes, your majesty."

"Prost, I want those palisades built *now*. Forget about the houses—go around the village and find out how many entrances there are. Don't go alone though—from now on, no one strays beyond the boundaries of the village unless they're with an escort. And within it...we need sentries,

weapons in case there's an attack, a place for children and the elderly to hide—"

People around me burst into action as I snap, breaking the silence Beniar's words have caused. I'm scrambling, searching for the right orders. *Are they the right ones?* I don't know, but I am obeyed. And no one else will take charge; that's my job.

The minutes after Beniar tells me about the ambush are watchful, tense. The rest of the Windfrozen Riders and the Celestial Trackers led by Odveig head out while Wiskeria mixes more of the poultice to neutralize the poisoned arrow.

Beniar has fainted. He screamed as we pulled the arrow out. Now he's pale, but the poison in him seems to be neutralized by whatever Wiskeria's made. I saw her pulling roots, dried bugs, and even an egg out of a pouch and pounding it all into the paste she made.

I'm glad she's here. I pace around the barn until I realize everyone's staring at me. Then I force myself to wait for an age before Odveig gets back.

"We found the place where Beniar was attacked. There's no sign of Fabiel or his horse. We followed the tracks for a bit, but we pulled back."

"Why?"

Odveig hesitates. She draws me aside and I realize I shouldn't be discussing this where all of the frightened villagers can hear. She whispers to me.

"I felt we were being watched from afar. I couldn't tell where the Goblins were and if we were ambushed—"

"I understand. I trust your decision. However, we have a problem Odveig. What should we do now, according to your expertise?"

She looks at me. I can sense her head turning, hear the hesitation and fear in her reply.

"I—your majesty, I've hunted Goblins before. But I've never been hunted by them. Were I alone, I'd track them and risk a battle on their terms or retreat until I could set my own traps. But defending a village means I

can't do either. I could send half of my group out and keep the other half here to defend, but that would create two weak points for them to exploit."

She's explaining. That means she doesn't know. I nod.

"In that case we'll wait. Pull your team back around the village. I'll—decide whether to send out scouts later."

"Yes, your majesty."

So there it stands. As Wiskeria finishes tending to Beniar, she estimates that he'll be able to take a healing potion the next day. Prost is mustering the villagers, and they've begun working. The Celestial Trackers and Windfrozen Riders are keeping a tight perimeter around the nearby forest and village.

And I'm sitting by myself, trying to figure out what to do.

The enemy is out there but invisible. Their numbers are unknown. Their levels unknown. They could be just a stone's throw outside the village's limits and I wouldn't know. There's a way to deal with that, actually. I've been working on it for a while, but I've been told that it will take a few more days. I want to insist, but it's only a chance. Not worth counting on.

What are my assets? What are my weak spots? My assets are two Silver-rank teams. My weakness is a need to defend my village. The Windfrozen Riders are a group of ten—were a group of ten suited to rapid attacks and retreats. Perfect for scouting—not for taking out armored enemies or hunting hidden foes. If they know where the enemy is I can send them at the Goblins. Assuming they're not hopelessly outnumbered.

The Celestial Trackers are the opposites of the Windfrozen Riders in many ways. They're experienced at ambushes, tracking their prey—finding hidden monsters, in short.

I've a [Mage] in the Windfrozen Riders who can cut his opponents with air spells. Nothing powerful; it'll take an eye out and he can cast while

riding, but Wiskeria's the only truly specialized spellcaster in either group. And she can't throw fireballs. I asked.

"Your majesty? Prost is asking permission to fell a few trees further into the forest. Miss Odveig thinks it's safe, but he wanted to ask you."

I look up and sense Gamel hovering about me. I nod.

"That's fine. Ah, what else is going on? Have you, Durene and the others begun training? Without Beniar, you'll need to get another adventurer to teach you—and what about the markers Jelov was working on? How many has he finished?"

"Three, sire, with one for varnishing. But he says he'll have another one tonight..."

And just like that, the day continues. Villagers get to work, taking care not to stray far but doing everything they were doing yesterday. Cutting wood, building—only there's an undercurrent of fear to everything, now.

Odd, it feels as though everyone should be hiding or getting ready. But you can't tell when the enemy will come. So the day passes, filled with anxiety and watchfulness, but nothing else. That's life now. The threat of death is in the air, but we have to continue living.

Damn the Goblins.

Day 67

I think everyone in the village was awake late at night. Certainly the villagers were a lot quieter the next day. I felt awful and Durene wasn't her spirited self; but we got through the morning and midway through the day without incident.

Beniar was up and about by that time. The poison had been flushed out of his system and a healing potion had him on his feet in minutes.

"Your majesty, I'm as fit as can be. I'd ride out to hit those Goblins in a flash if we knew where they were! Just give the order and I'll scout with my group—far faster than the Trackers!"

He's also itching to find the Goblins and exact payback for Fabiel, his teammate. I have to overrule Beniar, though.

"I can't let you leave the village unprotected, Beniar. I'm sorry for your friend's loss, but it's too risky. If you're shot at again—"

"I'll know it's coming this time, sire. Last time was an ambush. This time I'll dodge."

"I have no doubt you would. But my villagers can't dodge arrows like you."

Instead of Beniar riding forth, I let him teach the villagers and Durene. There's definitely a renewed interest in learning to fight now, and thanks to my Skill, the villagers are fighting well. But we don't have enough swords to go around; Helm is working on forging some, but he lacks enough iron, let alone steel to make many. Without that, people are training with pitchforks, shovels—Gamel has a club he's hammered nails into. He keeps asking to trade it for a sword with someone.

"A ragtag army, sire. But it'll do for a small group of Goblins."

Beniar's professional opinion is that the villagers are ready for a fight if the adventurers support them. I wonder if they'll break and run if it comes to that. The villagers might have the ability to fight thanks to my Skill, but the temperament? No.

As the sun is halfway down in the sky, I hear a horn call and leap to my feet, abandoning a lunch with Durene. It's not a Goblin horn—this one's from the Celestial Trackers and urgent. I rush outside with the others and see a woman wearing a dark brown cloak sprinting into the village, shouting.

I think we were all waiting for it. The villagers freeze and I turn my head.

"Odveig?"

She's already running to the adventurer.

"Report!"

There's no hesitation in her voice now, as there always is around me. The woman gasps for air—she must have been on the perimeter, scouting

the forest.

“Goblin group. Five hundred meters to the southeast—I saw two Hobs and at least thirty smaller Goblins!”

“That’s our cue! Let’s ride!”

Beniar’s already mounted. Odveig turns to me as Wiskeria runs up, clutching her magical wand.

“Your majesty?”

I hesitate only for a moment.

“Do it. If you hear a horn call from here, double back at once.”

The adventurers nod and race out of the village, Beniar leading and shouting, sword already drawn. They’re gone for five agonizing minutes and I hear nothing. Then, to my surprise, they all return at once.

Odveig and Wiskeria are on foot, and practically dragging an incensed Beniar back. He dismounts, shaking with anger.

“*Nothing*. They’ve covered their tracks. We could follow them, but Wiskeria and Odveig both agreed we’d be walking into an ambush. We let them get away!”

“It was the only smart choice, Beniar.”

Wiskeria defends herself as she argues with the leader of the Windfrozen Riders. Beniar’s voice is hot.

“I’d ride them down if I knew where they were, ambush or not! We could have attacked—”

“And done what? Two Hobgoblins were in that group. If they got the drop on your riders—”

“Better than letting them attack again! I’m telling you, we had the advantage!”

“Against thirty? You idiot, together we’re only twenty in number, and with two *Hobs*—”

“Enough!”

I raise my voice to stop the argument. Everyone looks at me. I'm aware of the villagers listening to the adventurers shouting. This can't be good for morale.

"You three, come with me. Prost? We're going to make a plan."

And so we do. It's not easy, and no one's happy by the end of it. All three adventurers reluctantly agree that pursuing the Goblins is a bad idea without making absolutely sure there's not a trap waiting. If there are only thirty, it's a close match thanks to the two Hobgoblins. If there's more we haven't seen...

Guard duty. The Windfrozen Riders are now to stay in the village while the Trackers keep watch. At the nearest sign of trouble, the Riders will attack any Goblins that are spotted. That's all we can do. Meanwhile, Prost is working double-time on the palisades. We've got the portion of the village around the barn walled off; hopefully that will help if we're attacked.

If we're attacked.

What a thought. That night, I stay up while Durene sleeps beside me. I can't say she's not as worried as I am, but she's been hammering sharpened logs of wood into the ground and lifting felled trees all day. She sleeps like a rock, snoring gently beside me.

Frostwing is agitated. I think she can smell the Goblins, or sense the tension in the air. She flaps her wings at night, forgetting she's supposed to be asleep. I have to get up and soothe her.

"Shh, Frostwing. There's a good bird. Eat some meat—damn, not my finger! I know. I know. There are monsters out there. But you have to wait, understand? We don't know where they are."

She cocks her head at me in the darkness. I think she's beginning to understand more of what I say. I smile as I stroke her head.

"A shame you can't find them for me. I did ask, you know—I'm not an idiot. But Odveig says Goblins eat anything they can kill, and I won't risk one putting an arrow into you."

Frostwing nips at my fingers as if to agree. I'm laughing when my heart stops. It does stop, I'm sure. For a moment the steady beat in my chest

falters. The next, I'm shouting.

"There's a Goblin in the village!"

"Wha?"

Durene wakes up as I shout. She struggles in her bed, flailing around for me.

"Laken? What's happening? Is something wrong?"

"Durene, get up! There's a Goblin in the village! It's gotten past the adventurers!"

"Oh no! Dead gods—where?"

She springs to her feet. Durene sleeps practically naked. I grab her bare arm.

"It's got a bow and a knife. I think they're poisoned."

I can sense the Goblin all the way in the village. It's moving slowly, very carefully avoiding the attention of anyone awake. And it's making for —

"Where, Laken? I'll raise the alarm!"

Durene's voice is tense. I can sense her fists clenched. I hesitate for a moment out of fear. What if she's hurt? But she's Durene. I make up my mind.

"Go! It's behind Prost's house!"

She doesn't wait for another word. I hear thundering footsteps, and then the door to Durene's cottage is thrown open. The half-Troll girl races down the road, running faster than I've ever seen her go. I pause at the doorway, about to run out myself and realize I'll never catch her.

So I close the door as the icy wind pours into the cottage and Frostwing screams. I find one of Durene's knives and dress myself as I mentally follow her progress down into the village.

She's running. The Goblin is doing something behind Prost's house, checking a window, seeing if it's unlatched. It freezes as Durene comes running into the village and squeezes down, hiding. Durene races around Prost's house and it freezes.

It has a dagger in its hand. I can see it all in my mind, like some kind of awful movie without sound. Durene doesn't see the Goblin—she's looking right in its direction, but she doesn't *see* it.

Then the Goblin leaps. It jumps out of the place where its hiding and slashes at Durene. She recoils—the Goblin runs around her, racing for the forest. I see Durene turn, and then her hand. She grabs the Goblin and it slashes at her arm.

I sense the blade sinking into Durene's skin; see her mouth open in my head, the wordless howl. But then Durene's other hand comes up. She *breaks* the Goblin's neck like she would a chicken's, in a moment.

It's all over. I can sense Prost and his family waking up in alarm, sense villagers and the adventurers racing towards Durene. By this point I'm running towards the village.

“Dead.”

That's the first pronouncement one of the [Scouts] in the Celestial Trackers makes when we're all in the village. The Goblin's corpse has been dragged out into the center of the village and everyone is shivering around it, staring down at the small body in the snow.

I'm there too, the only person who's dressed. Durene is hiding in Prost's house. She's naked, and by that I mean she's got underwear on and—yeah, that's about it. Modesty came after saving Prost's life, and so she's a hero everyone politely thanks—through a closed door.

Wiskeria is kneeling by the Goblin, intent on it. Beniar and Odveig are both patrolling, looking for more Goblins. They're rattled by one getting through their perimeter and worry another one's out there.

I know there's not another Goblin in the village, but I don't tell anyone how I know. To the villagers, Durene's simply a hero who uncovered the Goblin by accident. It's better that way.

“You're sure it's dead?”

Yesel asks the [Scout] anxiously as she clings to her husband. Prost has a pitchfork—hardly an elegant weapon, but the tines are sharp and he seems ready to use it. The [Scout] nods as he inspects the body.

“Neck’s broken. Not many Goblins survive that. You say that Miss Durene did it with one hand? Never heard of that before.”

He shakes his head and whistles quietly as the other villagers murmur. I’m not surprised; I know how strong Durene is.

“So what was the green skinned bastard doing here?”

Prost’s voice is rough as he steps forward and looks at the Goblin. I start.

Green skin? I’ve never seen colors, but I know how things are supposed to look. Grass is green. And Goblin skin is the same color? I can’t imagine it, or fit together the feel of grass with—with a Goblin.

“At a guess, it was coming here to slaughter you all in your sleep. The dagger isn’t poisoned, but it’s dressed in black, see? No need for poison when you can cut a throat easier.”

“Dead gods.”

Yesel buries her head in Prost’s shoulder. He clutches one of his daughters to his side.

“We’ve you to thank Durene, truly.”

“I’m glad you’re okay!”

Durene calls from inside. The [Scout] is checking the Goblin for anything else as I kneel down next to him.

“You said the Goblin has green skin? Ah...it’s Jeighya, isn’t it?”

“Yes, your majesty.”

I sense him looking sideways at me, and starting a bit as he realizes that I wouldn’t know what a Goblin looks like. He clears his throat.

“They’ve all green skin, some shade of it, sire. Red eyes, too. The color of monsters. Just as well this one won’t open its eyes again.”

It takes me a minute to remember how our eyes are supposed to look. White and colored in the center, right? Just another thing to distinguish Goblins, but in my head—

“I’ve never seen one. It’s not dangerous in any way now, right Jeighya?”

“No sire, but why—”

I kneel down and gently feel the Goblin with my hand. I pat gingerly at the skin, feel the arms, and then, slowly, the face. It’s a surreal feeling, touching something dead.

So this is a Goblin. I kneel down and touch the body gently. It feels... like any body would, I guess. Only smaller. Colder.

I feel like I’m touching a dead child. I shudder and pull my hand back. But for the sharp ears and pointed teeth, I’d think it *was* a young Human kid. I can’t see the green skin or the crimson eyes.

Standing, I look at the other villagers. They’re anxiously clustered around. I raise my voice, grateful I’m dressed. The dignity of an [Emperor] and all that. I’m not about to recreate the story of the emperor’s new clothes right now.

“We’re safe for now. Please thank Durene for finding and taking care of the Goblin. In the morning, though. Right now I think everyone should get to sleep; I doubt we’ll see more trouble tonight.”

The villagers are hardly reassured by my words, but they do take some comfort by a dead Goblin. They disperse slowly, murmuring anxiously. I turn to Jeighya.

“Keep a watch. They might try this again.”

Unfortunately, that night I’m made into a liar. There are no Goblins that I sense entering the village, but they are active after Durene makes her way back to her cottage, modesty preserved by a borrowed towel.

Two hours after the Goblin is caught, someone fires a flaming arrow into the side of the barn. The villagers put the fire out before it spreads, but a second arrow hits a house and sets the roof ablaze. The village is filled with fear and no one gets a lot of sleep that night.

Day 68

Discontent. That's the mood in the village the next day, after the villagers wake up from a sleepless night and see the smoke and burnt roof.

Many of them haven't slept since the first fire. Neither have I. I slept through the first arrow until Gamel ran to wake me, and when I sensed the second fire starting I went down to the village and stayed there until morning.

The roof of one of the villager's houses is toast, but it could be worse. That's what I tell myself as I cough, smelling the burnt wood in the morning. But it's still bad.

The Goblins are harassing us with attacks, striking and fleeing since their attempt to send an assassin in failed. The two arrows were fired from the forest. Both times the Celestial Trackers found the Goblins and exchanged shots with them in the dark. The second time they got one of the Goblins in the stomach, but they found only bloodstains and no body when they went to check.

No one's happy about that. But the villagers are the least happy it seems. Especially the ones from Windrest.

They don't know me. I'm an [Emperor] to them, a strange, majestic class and a blind man with few impressive qualities to recommend him blended into one being. I must confuse them terribly.

I've talked with them of course, and tried to reassure them along with the Riverfarm people, but I know I'm not too convincing at this moment. I don't have the same bond with them as I do with the Riverfarm people. And it shows.

If I separate the interactions I have, the people fall into three broad groups. The first are like Helm and the older villagers like Jelov. They treat me like Prost and Gamel and the others, grateful for the protection I offer mainly.

The others are more distant. I'm a [Lord] to them, and since the aristocracy of this land can be touchy, they're wary of me. Still, if they have their complaints they keep their feelings private.

However, the last group is vocal in their grievances. Quietly vocal since saying I'm a bad ruler is an invitation to a fight if someone like Gamel hears it. But nevertheless, the lid is boiling. And things get worse when the Goblins step up their attacks the next morning.

One of the [Hunters] comes back with an arrow in his thigh and cuts along his arm. The Windfrozen Riders gallop off as I hear what happened.

"Arrow. I was at my post when I saw a group of Goblins coming towards me. They showered my position—ran before help came."

He's not badly wounded, but the incident speaks to how defenseless we are. And the Windfrozen Riders don't find the Goblins either. Too slow, and the Goblins know how fast the horses can move. So we get back to work. We have healing potions, but how long until they run out? I can hear the villagers talking, sense their nervous postures, and sense the few who are vocally worried. That worry and fear turns to resentment.

But what can I do? Wiskeria's still arguing against any attempts to go out and hunt the Goblins down, and I agree. But Beniar points out the obvious each time too—if we don't do anything, we'll just keep being attacked. I think Odveig wants me to decide and I—

I can't risk it. It's too dangerous. And while the adventurers understand that, the villagers only see them patrolling and not hunting the monsters. That leads to an incident at lunch.

I'm about to go check on the villagers training with Beniar. It's the one thing I feel like I have control over, the thing that I can do to really prepare for the Goblins. I hear someone's voice raised as I pass by one of the tables set up in the barn where food is distributed communally.

"Some [Emperor]. Any proper [Lord]'d keep his people safe, but this one just sits about while we suffer in fear. I thought we were supposed to be *safe* here!"

I'm clearly meant to hear that. I turn my head and sense a group of Windrest folk sitting at a table. The person who speaks...I think it's a woman sitting in the middle of the party.

Her words don't pass by unnoticed either. Heads turn. There aren't many villagers in the barn, but the ones who are from Windrest stare at me

and the ones from Riverfarm stand up.

Uh oh. I wave to my villagers and walk over to the woman before her words can start a brawl. She's sitting there, defiant, surrounded by her friends. I stop before her table.

"Do you have an issue with me, Miss?"

I'm looking right at her. That throws her for a loop already, I can tell. But the woman rallies in a moment. She looks around the room and speaks directly to me.

"I do. You're an [Emperor]. You promised us folk of Windrest we'd be safe if we joined your village. But those Goblins are attacking and you've not done a thing! You hide here while we're shot at—in a few days we'll be dead for you doing nothing!"

Her words cause a susurraton around the barn. And for all the people of Riverfarm are speaking angrily, watching the woman with ill-intent, I can tell they're agreeing a bit with what she said. I speak calmly, looking down at her.

"I am doing everything in my power to keep you all safe. I assumed two Silver-rank teams were adequate protection for Goblins. I was wrong, and for that I am sorry. However, you are still safer here than you would be on the road or in another village. It's too dangerous to risk sending the adventures out to hunt the Goblins—they could walk into a trap or leave the village defenseless, and in both cases, we'd all die for my mistakes. I'm not willing to take that chance. You may disagree, but I am choosing the best options as I see fit."

My words are the truth. That's my weapon and how I sway the villagers. I can sense some nodding around the room. How could you argue with that logic? And I do have a plan for the Goblins. I just need more time. A little more time and...besides, how could you argue with that?

With emotion, that's how. Perhaps she feels like she's at a disadvantage now, but the woman stands up. I think her name's Rehanna. I can sense her glare, even if I can't see it.

"Big words for a man who can't see! How're we supposed to trust the word of a *blind* man? You can't tell who you're talking to, can you? We

must all be the same to you.”

That makes me mad. Why do some people seem to think that blindness means I can’t tell people apart or sense where I am? People have voices, tones, and ways of speaking. Idiots who try and change their voices to make me think they’re someone else really get on my nerves. But I don’t snap. I cross my arms.

“I am blind. So what? I am an [Emperor], not a [Warrior]. Why shouldn’t I be as capable as any other [Emperor]—let alone a [Lord]—at my job?”

“You know why. Blind people are—they’re not the same!”

Now that—that’s an insult. I hear a woman behind me shout something towards Rehanna. It sounds like a threat. I cut her off with a hand. I’m angry now. My voice is loud in my ears.

“If I was a [Warrior], I suppose being blind might be a problem. If I were a [Painter], I would understand people having their reservations. But I have known blind painters, blind singers; men and women who have done as well as—if not better than any person with sight in their own way. A blind man climbed the world’s highest mountain. I have met him and shaken his hand.”

Silence. I have spoken the truth. But the woman denies it. To my face. She shakes her head and makes a sound like a scoff. Because she doesn’t want to believe what I say is true, she thinks I’m lying.

The nerve. I’m fighting not to open my eyes and use [Intimidating Glare]—or punch her at this point. Either one would be satisfying, but it’s not how I win this argument. People are watching. I’ll beat her with words.

“I don’t think you’re a proper [Emperor], not a real one. I won’t bow to you. What do you say to that? Will you throw me out for disobeying?”

“No, but I might cut off your head.”

Just words. Satisfying, savage words. The woman chokes. I fight down some guilty pleasure as the people around me gasp in horror. I smile slightly.

“I am an [Emperor]. Do you think a true [Emperor] would let a challenge to his rule go unanswered?”

I don't think she did. I turn around the room, speaking to everyone listening. Calm. Project calm and confidence.

"I am an [Emperor]. If I walked around naked or covered in tree sap, I would still be an [Emperor]. Your belief matters not. *I am an [Emperor]*. And this is my demesne."

I don't think she knows that word either. The woman makes another sound but refuses to back down. She's cornered by her own actions now. I can sense her approaching. She stops a few feet away from me, glaring.

"Please."

I don't speak to her, but to the Riverfarm men and women who approach, looking ready to grab her. They stop, reluctantly, and I stare up into the woman's face. She's glaring at me.

Hah. That's funny. I smile and sense her stare faltering. She doesn't get the joke.

Fierce, glaring...it doesn't matter. I don't bother to use [Intimidating Glare]; there's no point. I can show these people that I can stand up for myself without a Skill.

She's pretty tall. I look up and meet Rehanna's eyes with my closed ones. I feel her hesitate. I almost smile, but keep my composure. Internally though, I have to smile a bit. Yeah, that's right. Didn't think about it too hard, did you? What's the point of trying to scare me?

There's no way to stare down a blind man.

"You are frightened."

She starts and opens her mouth. I talk over her.

"You are frightened of the Goblins and afraid. I understand that. Everyone is frightened. However, we must work past our fear."

Heads are nodding around the room. I look past Rehanna, hearing her splutter for words, and then back at her.

"That doesn't excuse what you have said, but it tempers my decision. I won't kick you out of my village because that would be cruel and you would die. And I won't order you beheaded or beaten, and I'll make sure no

one harasses you. When this is over, you're free to go. But until then, you will address me with respect."

She hesitates. Now would be the time when she apologizes. Does she? Not a chance. That would imply she'd thought any of this through. Instead, she thrusts her chin at me.

"I won't kneel to you. I came here to survive, but I won't bow and scrape under your rule no matter what you offer."

I hear someone growl. Actually growl. I just sigh. Why is it that some people will keep digging a hole when they're already ten feet under?

"I won't ask you to kneel, but I will have you obey. And if I were you, I wouldn't say another word."

I turn. At some point you have to walk away from a stupid argument or end up being just as stupid. And I have more important work to do. I'm halfway out of the barn when I hear the woman's voice.

"Or what?"

That's it. I pause. The barn is silent, and I can sense the woman behind me. Trembling with bravado and fear. Trembling. I can see in my head her every flaw, her imperfections. Why does she pretend? I can see right through her.

I don't turn. I open my mouth and say one word.

"Kneel."

I hear a gasp and someone falls to her knees. I keep walking and don't look back.

Do I feel good about that moment? Yes. I gave Rehanna every chance and she kept pushing. I was lenient in this. Far too lenient, perhaps. But everyone saw.

Next time, if she's stupid enough for a next time, I'll have to get nasty. I don't want to imagine what I'll do, I only know that it will be unpleasant for me—and quite unpleasant for her. I don't fully care. Sometimes you have to trample over people, I guess. That's what it means to rule. She'll obey, or I'll have to crush her—

Wait, crush her? Where did *that* thought come from?

Troubled, I make my way over to the training grounds—a patch of cleared dirt where I can hear people shouting and hitting each other or the wooden sticks that have been set up. And then I hear a far more pleasant female voice.

“Laken!”

It’s Durene. I hadn’t seen her this morning—as usual she’s been rushing about the village, helping people out. I regret not being able to spend more time with her. And she has a surprise for me.

“I’m a Level 9 [Paladin]! I got a Skill—guess what it is? Guess!”

She must have leveled up from the training and killing the Goblin. I smile at her.

“I’m no good at guessing.”

“Just guess anyways!”

“Okay...[Shield of Radiance]? [Holy Hands]? [Sword of Justice]?”

A pause. Durene sounds downcast.

“No...those sound like great Skills. Mine isn’t that good.”

“Durene...I made those up. Whatever Skill you have is wonderful. But you did ask.”

I sigh, but smile at her. Durene perks back up.

“You did? Okay, then. Well I got...are you sure you don’t want to guess again? No? Okay, I got...[Quick Strike]!”

“Oh! That’s great!”

I try to sound as happy as she is. Honestly, I have no idea if that’s a good Skill. It sounds...cheap? But Durene seems happy about it.

“Let me show you how it works. I was going to try it with Beniar.”

“Yes, Durene told me all about it. [Quick Strike]’s a basic move. It’s more common to get [Power Strike] and move from there, but Durene’s strong enough. I’ve a shield—why don’t you try and touch me? She hasn’t so far Emperor Laken. Today might be her lucky day, though.”

Beniar's a bit too cocky and full of pent-up energy at the moment. I've seen him training with Durene and the others and he doesn't let anyone touch him with a sword no matter how hard they try. I suppose he's got the Skills, but it does seem like bullying at times.

Durene's never come close before. She has that wooden club of course, and her shield, and both are too slow for Beniar who's adept at dodging and keeping his distance. Now Durene takes a stance and gingerly swings at him.

"Too slow!"

Beniar laughs as he ducks her club and nimbly springs forward to tap Durene on the stomach with his practice sword. She jumps and swings her shield at him, but he's already moving back. I sigh internally, frustrated a bit.

It's not that Durene's that slow, I think she's also afraid of hitting Beniar, a fact which he capitalizes on. I've seen them do this before, and I don't want to see Beniar bullying Durene for a few minutes. However, today's my lucky day.

"Take this!"

Durene lashes out with her shield and Beniar sways back. The shield misses him and he grins. He's taking a step back when Durene shouts.

"[Quick Strike]!"

Her arm blurs. I hear Beniar's voice and a thud almost at the same time.

"Oh *sh*—"

To his credit, I think Beniar saw it coming. He tried to block and then dodge when he saw the club coming. But he was too slow.

Thanks to my [Emperor] senses, I saw the entire thing. Beniar stepping back, the sudden acceleration of Durene's club to wicked fast speeds—and the impact. I enjoyed it more than I should.

In the aftermath, Durene stands horror-struck over Beniar as everyone turns to stare at her.

"I didn't mean to! I didn't—is he alive?"

He's groaning on the ground, which answers her question. I squat next to him and speak gently.

"Good thing Durene was aiming for your chest, huh, Beniar? I don't want to imagine what your head would have been like."

"Agh! No, sire."

A bit of fun, a bit of frustration. Neither occurrence goes unnoticed. Soon, Beniar's up and treating Durene with a lot more respect, and Prost's seeking me out.

"I heard what happened, Emperor Laken. I've had a word with that Rehanna woman, and let me apologize for her words, sire. Few folk think like her—"

"But they do think like her, Prost. Don't worry, I'm not offended—or vengeful. But if people feel that way, I'd like to know. Preferably without the rudeness, but I'd still rather know than not."

"Yes, sire. I'm sure she'd never have said as much, but that woman's a hothead and a malcontent. And I think she was prompted to it."

That gets my attention. I stop as Prost and I walk around the village.

"Prompted, Prost?"

"Yes, sire. Rehanna won't speak to me—stubborn as a mule—but her friends say she's been talking with someone else, getting an earful of what to say to you, maybe. Apparently she's been having a drink as she does. Building courage to say such things."

"Alcohol? I didn't buy more than a cask—we don't have any in the village, unless the Windrest people brought it...?"

"No, your Majesty. And Rehanna didn't have any herself. There's only one group that brought some drink with them—"

"The adventurers."

“Yes, sire. If you want I can ask around, see who’s been spreading rumors about you—”

“No, Prost. Thank you. I think...I have an idea of who it might be. I’ll handle it myself.”

“Yes, sire.”

Oh boy. That’s not good. I excuse myself and leave Prost behind and go for a walk. I have a bad feeling in my chest. I’ve had it before, but I was worrying about the Goblins. Now...a few things are falling into place.

Pieces. It’s just pieces in my head, but they fit together in a way I don’t like. A few odd events have caught my attention. Someone breaking into my cottage while I was away, the missing Mossbear fur and it attacking the village—and now someone stirring up trouble and prompting people to challenge me.

It could all be coincidence, but I know for a fact that the people of Windrest were all settling in on the day my cottage was broken into. None of them would have known where I lived, much less done anything on that day.

And the Windfrozen riders were all riding patrol—save for Beniar and a few who were training the volunteers from the village. That rules them out.

So that only leaves the Celestial Trackers and the people of Riverfarm as suspects. If you rule out Riverfarm—because if they were going to snoop, why not do it when I wasn’t there?—then that leaves only one group.

And of that group...only one person I can think of would want to get ahold of Mossbear fur. After all, [Witches] can hex opponents and cast all kinds of spells. Why *not* do voodoo tricks with hair? As for my cottage and stirring up the Windrest villagers, well, if it’s all part of a larger reason...

Suspicious. I can’t rely just on my intuition and throwaway guesses for this. I have to confirm it.

It’s not hard to find Jeighya. He’s not patrolling and the man is maintaining his bow. I sit with him and he reacts—well, cautiously but with a good deal of friendliness. I’m not some aloof [Emperor] and we have bonded over a dead Goblin’s corpse.

“I’ve been wondering about your group, Jeighya. It seems weird to me that a [Witch] is part of your party. I’ve never met one and I was hoping you could explain their class to me. I’d ask Wiskeria, but I wouldn’t want to be rude.”

“Oh? I’d be happy to share what I know, your majesty. [Witches] are a rare class, I’ll say, but they’ve got useful Skills and spells most common [Mages] would turn their nose up at learning. Wiskeria’s been a boon to us, for all she’s new.”

“New?”

My heart sinks. The man with the bow nods as he fumbles with an arrow.

“She wasn’t in our party last spring. Wiskeria and Odveig—they’re old friends. Older’n they seem, I know. Odveig formed our group a while back—she’s not always leading us, but she’s always around Invisil.”

“Oh. I thought she’d been part of your group forever. And Odveig’s not your leader?”

He pauses, scratches at his beard.

“Not so much that she’s not our leader as much as that we don’t adventure together all the time like most groups, sire. Begging your pardon. We don’t take on that many contracts each year; a lot of us make our livings from hunting and join up when she says there’s word of a good contract. But Wiskeria now, she joined the group not two months ago. Came out of nowhere, but Odveig knew her and she’s a good thinker. Her spells have gotten us out of a lot of scraps.”

“I see. And she’s got a lot of talents? Did I hear she can manipulate animals?”

“Oh yes! Very helpful that is. I saw her pull a Corusdeer’s fur out one time and summoned an entire herd later. Helped us take down some Snow Golems. ‘Course, it’s harder to make animals do what doesn’t come naturally, but Corusdeer love killing Snow Golems. Natural enemies.”

“You don’t say.”

Wiskeria. I let Jeighya drone on about monsters as the worry in my head grows. It was just a suspicion. Now...now I think I have a serious problem.

That night I summoned Wiskeria to Durene's cottage. It wasn't hard; I mentioned that I wanted to see her, and so she came. Nothing out of the ordinary.

Nothing out of the ordinary with Durene being there either. Frostwing being gone might have raised an eyebrow, but she doesn't mention it. Durene barring the door though...

"Your majesty? Is something wrong?"

Wiskeria glances towards Durene as I sit at her dining table, across from Wiskeria. I sigh. I don't want to do this. I don't want to be right.

"Nothing much. I just wanted to clear up a few things, Wiskeria."

The [Witch] glances towards Durene and back at me.

"I'm at your majesty's service."

"Are you? Good. So tell me something. Why's there a clump of Mossbear fur in your pouches?"

She freezes. I stare at her. It wasn't hard to sense the distinct fur in Wiskeria's belt pouch. And when I found it, I knew.

I knew.

Silence. I can sense Durene glaring at Wiskeria. She knows. I told her, and no one else. I didn't want to alarm anyone in case I was wrong, but... the fur. I'm waiting for an explanation and hoping against hope that I'm mistaken.

Because I *think* Wiskeria's trying to sabotage my village. I think she's my enemy, and I don't know why. But something Ryoka mentioned to me makes me think she might be in this Lady Magnolia Reinhart's employ. It's just a hunch, but Ryoka says Magnolia sent [Assassins] after her. Why not a spy masquerading as an adventurer in Wiskeria's case?

At last, Wiskeria opens her mouth. She glances at me and Durene, and I'd bet she's lost all color in her face. I always wondered what that would

look like. How would that work? And why does it happen when you're scared? Blood flow? It makes no sense.

"I—know how it must seem, your majesty. But I swear I took the fur before the Mossbear woke up, while it slept! I was sure I did it stealthily enough not to wake it—you have my oath on that!"

"Oh? And so this Mossbear just woke up around the same time you cut the hair? You didn't set it on the village with a spell?"

"Me? Set it on the village?"

Wiskeria repeats my words as if she can't believe what I'm saying. She hesitates. The pieces click together and she bursts out.

"But I—no! I would never intentionally wake it if there was no reason! Emperor Laken, please believe me! My taking the hair was just a precaution! I've no notion why the bear woke up. If it was my fault, it was a mistake I truly regret!"

"Really."

I stare at her. Wiskeria's trembling. Is it an act? I clear my throat.

"Very well. Say I believe you, Wiskeria. Onto another matter."

"Another...?"

She says it as if she has no idea what might be coming next. I nod gently.

"Someone was in my cottage. It wasn't one of the villagers. I'd suspect one of the Windfrozen Riders, but they were patrolling a good ways out from the village. However, I recall that the Celestial Trackers were deployed closer to the village. Just in case. Which means you could have snuck in on that day."

"I—are you—"

I fold my arms. I can hear Durene's teeth grinding from here. Wiskeria makes a few incoherent noises. Then—

"I didn't do it. I cannot prove I wasn't there, but—I would swear to it under truth spell."

“Too bad we don’t have one. And I suppose you had nothing to do with a villager from Windrest named Rehanna challenging me publically today?”

“No! How could you assume I’d—”

“Mossbear attack, going through my cottage, inciting my subjects...all actions worthy of a [Spy].”

“You mean—me?”

Disbelief. Shock. A hint of outrage, but mostly confusion and fear. That’s what my ears tell me and my senses confirm Wiskeria’s posture matches these emotions. For a moment I feel uncertain.

She sounds very convincing for a spy. But isn’t that what any trained spy would sound like? My stomach hurts. I can only trust in what I’ve observed, the conclusions I’ve come to.

“Emperor Laken. Your majesty.”

Wiskeria licks her lips, clearly afraid. She glances at Durene again before speaking urgently to me.

“I did not do—any of the things you believe I did. I *did* take the Mossbear’s fur, but only as a precaution! Its attack was a mistake, and I swear that’s the truth.”

“And the other things? Are they coincidences?”

“Perhaps. Perhaps not. They seem suspicious—but I can only say I had nothing to do with them.”

She says it faintly, knowing how it must sound. I sigh.

“I don’t believe you, Wiskeria.”

I hold up a hand as she protests.

“...But I can’t prove you’re not telling the truth. So here’s what I’m going to do. I’m going to imprison you. Take away your wand, put you in a house and under guard...and ask some questions. If you can’t answer them, or your friends can’t, well—”

“I can’t accept that. Sire.”

Wiskeria interrupts me, sounding panicked. She half-pushes back her chair.

“I would be in danger for my life if your villagers found out what I was accused of. They—your subjects would kill for you. I don’t want to die or be held captive for weeks.”

“Sit down.”

Durene growls at Wiskeria. The [Witch] hesitates, and does not. I look at her.

“You have no choice, Wiskeria. I’m not about to risk another incident, or working with someone I can’t trust.”

I can’t. Not now so much is at stake. But Wiskeria is shaking her head.

“No, I can’t—won’t be held here when there are Goblins about! What if they attack?”

She speaks pleadingly to me.

“I’m willing to leave and void my contract, Emperor Laken. After the Goblins are dealt with. Or return with a truth spell testimony proving my innocence. But I can’t let you take my wand.”

“Wiskeria, I have no choice. You have to know how this looks—”

“I do. And I’m sorry for this. [Paralyzing Touch].”

Before I can react, I feel her finger on my chest. I gasp and my body goes rigid. Durene shouts. I sense Wiskeria going for the door.

My body’s frozen, but my mouth can still move.

“Wiskeria, stop! Don’t make this worse!”

She doesn’t reply. She’s ducking around Durene, hand raised, shimmering with magic. I can sense Durene hesitating. What do I do?

No good answer. But I know she can’t get away. I look to Durene standing by the door.

“Durene. Hit her. Gently, so she can’t get away.”

“No!”

Wiskeria backs up, hands raised as Durene makes a huge fist. She knows how strong Durene is. My half-Troll girlfriend could kill Wiskeria with a punch. Durene looms over Wiskeria, abandoning the door.

“Give up or I’ll hurt you.”

Wiskeria slowly raises her hands and backs towards a wall. She glances at me, and realizes she’s got no excuses. But she still speaks desperately.

“I’m innocent. You’ll see that in the end. Just don’t—I don’t want to die. Not here! I didn’t even *want* to take this contract on! I was against it!”

“What?”

Durene pauses for a second. Wiskeria speaks rapidly, eyes flicking left and right, too afraid to move and be hit.

“We normally take on contracts for monster exterminations, scouting, that sort of thing! We get the occasional request from the Reinhart family! I told Odveig there was no need to spend this much time on escort duty, but she insisted!”

“Odveig did?”

“Yes! She insisted! Said we’d get no better deal though we could have been hunting Frost Golems or making gold coins selling pelts! I have no idea why she wanted—”

“Wiskeria? I heard [Emperor] Laken wanted to talk to you, and I heard shouting. What’s going...?”

Someone opens the door. I sense Odveig come in.

“What the—? Odveig?”

Wiskeria gapes at her friend. Durene turns, but keeps her focus on Wiskeria. I’m...

Dumbfounded. Was that coincidence? No, it can’t be. That was movie-level timing right there. Was Odveig outside? Why was she here? *I didn’t notice she was outside the cottage!*

And suddenly the pieces in my head change. Odveig. Wiskeria’s actions. One of the Celestial Trackers. I shout.

“Durene! She’s the spy! Get her!”

Durene swings around. Odveig curses.

“Damn. He is smart.”

She steps nimbly to one side, unhooking her mace. Wiskeria is gaping, staring at me. Durene raises a hand.

“Hey, stop—”

Durene grabs for Odveig. The [Macewoman] steps back and as Durene misses, slides forward like a ghost. She taps Durene behind the knee with her mace and Durene’s leg collapses.

“Huh?”

The half-Troll girl goes down onto one leg, sounding stunned. She turns, reaches for Odveig, and Odveig taps her on the head with the mace.

“Sleep.”

I hear Durene hit the ground. My protector, my mighty [Paladin] knocked out. Just like that.

“Odveig!”

Wiskeria raises her hand. Odveig steps back as Wiskeria tries to touch her with the [Paralyzing Touch] spell. She hits Wiskeria; I hear a cry.

“Sorry, Wis. I didn’t want to let you take the blame...or let you find out this way. But I have a few secrets.”

The [Witch] crumples to the ground. I’m still locked in place by her spell. I sense Odveig coming around behind me, still holding her mace.

“Well, you are a very intelligent young man, Laken Godart.”

“Thanks. Is this the part where you tell me why you did what you did?”

I’m stalling for time. Odveig shrugs.

“You guessed. I’m a spy. That’s not my class, but...how did you know I broke into the cottage? How did you find out what was in Wiskeria’s bags without looking?”

“I sensed it.”

“Ah. Interesting.”

I feel all the hairs on the back of my neck trying to dance. I wait. Odveig moves closer.

“I have so much I’d like to ask you, but your protector might wake up soon and my cover is gone. So I’ll just say this.”

I feel someone brushing hair around my ears, and then a higher-pitched voice, an elegant tone, so unlike Odveig’s accented words.

“Lady Magnolia sends her regards. She will be very interested to speak with you once I deliver my report. If you survive.”

I feel a chill as Odveig whispers into my ear. I’m afraid to make the wrong move, tense. I can sense her holding her mace at her side.

“Who are you really? Why did Magnolia send you? What does she want?”

“I’m afraid I can’t say much, Laken. But my real name is...Sakra. I regret that we couldn’t speak under more pleasant circumstances.”

She shifts. I wait for the end, or at least, unconsciousness. But Odveig doesn’t lift it and smash my brains out. She turns and strides out of the cottage. I sense her pick up speed as she leaves—she’s running down to the village incredibly quickly. Then she’s on a horse, trotting it out of the village until she’s out of sight, and then racing it—

She’s gone.

It takes five minutes before my body starts being able to move again. Wiskeria’s magic wears off slowly, and I feel like I’m moving through molasses. My arms and legs tingle like they’ve been asleep. At last, I stand up, around the same time Wiskeria and Durene wake up.

Both of them get up and immediately start a riot. Wiskeria runs out of the cottage and Durene chases her shouting for Odveig. That leaves me in the cottage, alone. I put my head in my hands.

“Damn. I feel like an idiot.”

I’m an idiot. That’s my conclusion after the chaos, with Prost rousing the village and the Celestial Trackers demanding to know why Odveig’s run

and Wiskeria trying to defend herself and avoid Durene hitting her. I sort it out by shouting at everyone and kick myself that night.

I'm an idiot. Have I said it enough times? No. To put it in a delightfully American way, I done goofed. That's an appropriate way of thinking of how stupid I was.

What was my plan? Confront Wiskeria and hope she'd confess? And then what? Confine her as a prisoner or—kill her? Let her go? Aside from the fact that I was wrong, I didn't give any thought to what I was going to do.

I panicked. And because of that, Odveig's gone and I'm left with more questions and one less warrior to defend the village. If I had been smarter, I could have observed Odveig and let her help me—or see how far Magnolia was willing to go to attack me and my village.

Now I'm down another adventurer, and a good one if she can knock out Durene in a single hit. If only I'd...

Too late now. Too late. At least one of my worries has resolved itself. Only, now it's a bigger worry and I still have to worry about them.

The Goblins.

4.23 E

“I can’t believe it. It was Odveig—I mean, Sacra, the entire time?”

“Yes, Durene. I didn’t realize it until it was too late. Damnit, I feel like an idiot—”

“But how? She didn’t act like—she was always so respectful and—and not like a spy at all! I thought Wiskeria was odd when you said she might be the one, but—*Odveig*?”

“The best spy’s one you don’t see coming, Durene.”

“And she works for Lady Magnolia? I mean...*the* Lady Magnolia?”

“You know her?”

“Everyone does. She’s Magnolia Reinhart. She’s...why’d she want you, Laken? Why’d she send Odveig?”

“I don’t know. Curiosity, maybe. Or—no, it’s no use questioning it. But now she’s gone and we could have really used her, Odveig’s abilities.”

“Yeah. You know, when she hit me, I didn’t feel a thing? She just tapped my head, like that, and it was...poof! What level do you think she was?”

“High. It was a mistake to confront her. Not that I knew it was her. Now Wiskeria’s afraid she’s trapped in some political game, and the adventurers are nervous. It was a mistake to do this now.”

“But you know who was causing trouble now, right? That’s a good thing.”

“Yes, but we don’t know *why*, Durene. We don’t know why and if she did anything else and what she’ll tell Lady Magnolia. We don’t know—and the Goblins are still out there.”

“Yeah. They shot arrows at Gamel when he was cutting wood. Everyone’s afraid.”

“I know.”

“Oh! But they know you’ll take care of it! You have a plan, right Laken? Right?”

“I—I have something, Durene.”

“What is it?”

“It’s—well, it’s just a guess. An idea, really. The Goblins are hiding, and I’ve been taking...steps...to deal with them.”

“Steps is good. But what...? Is it a secret?”

“No. Just stupid. I mean, it sounds stupid in my head. It’s got to do with Jelov. I’ll—you know what? It’s time. I have to try it. Otherwise we’re in trouble. We’ve lost Odveig, I mean, Sacra, Durene. Everyone’s afraid. It’s only a matter of time before someone tries to run or gets killed, or people try to replace me—either way, that’s when the Goblins attack and we all die.”

“I won’t let them do that. I’ll kill them. All of them. By myself, if I have to.”

“...”

“Laken?”

“I know you’d do that, Durene. But it’s my job to—to make things easier. I’ll do it tomorrow. And the situation with Wiskeria and the others—we’ll deal with it afterwards.”

“What if she’s, you know, angry I tried to hit her?”

“Then she can be angry. But she’ll obey. We’re only coming out of this one way, Durene, and that’s if we stick together. And I’ll do it. I’ll make us fight as one if I have to force everyone to do it myself.”

“Oh. That’s good.”

“Really? That sounds terrible to me.”

“Well forcing people, yeah...but you’re you, Laken. I know you’ll help everyone, even if it means twisting their arms.”

“Hah. You always know what to say, Durene.”

“...”

“...”

“Laken? Are we going to die?”

“...No, Durene. I won’t let it happen.”

“Good. But if we do, I wanted to—”

“Shh. Go to sleep.”

“But I wanted to—”

“I know.”

“I love you.”

“I know. I love you too.”

Day 69

Three attacks. Arrows flying out of the woods and Goblins charging a group of the villagers. Both times there were only wounded, not the dead—the Windfrozen Riders chased the Goblins away before they could do more than cut at the villagers.

And yet, the pain is still there. I can hear a man screaming and whimpering before the healing potion is applied sparingly to his leg. An oval of flesh had been carved off of his leg.

It’s too much. I can sense the villagers’ fear, sense the adventurers wavering. Odveig’s sudden departure and the suspicion Wiskeria was put under has rattled both groups. Wiskeria’s in charge now, but she’s jumpy too. Whatever relationship I had with her is strained...

But we’re all in the same boat. I don’t know if Odveig—I mean, Sacra, got away safely, or if she was killed by the Goblins. We’re cut off right now. Isolated.

But not hopeless. Not yet. Once I’m done talking to Prost, I stride over to my one hope, my secret weapon, my ace in the hole.

Jelov looks up at me as I find him eating in the barn.

“Your majesty, can I do something for you?”

I don’t waste time with pleasantries.

“The markers, Jelov. Are they done?”

He sounds startled.

“Yes, your worship. Not polished as good as could be, but—”

“Good, have them brought out. I’ll be using them in a few moments.”

I leave him scrambling to get up and find Wiskeria. I think she’s trying to hide from me, but I know where she is. The [Witch] tenses.

“Your majesty, about Odveig. I—”

“Wiskeria, how dangerous would it be to go...let’s say four miles out of the village with a wagon and plant something in the ground?”

“Plant? What?”

She stares at me. I’m not making sense. I take a steadying breath. Calm down.

“I have six—no, seven wooden markers. Each one’s thick—and heavy. I’m sure you’ve seen Jelov carving them.”

“I—yes, sire?”

Still not making sense. I speak slower.

“I want to plant them in the ground. Each one needs to be hammered into the ground in a circle around Riverfarm. Deep. Somewhere where they won’t fall down, around four miles or so away from the village. Can it be done with a small group? Without danger?”

Wiskeria stares at me. She opens her mouth, hesitates, and then answers without asking the why of it.

“I suppose it’s possible, your majesty. It’d be a job for the Windfrozen Riders, and risky. If they’re attacked. Otherwise we could send out a huge band, but that would leave the village undefended and I guarantee the Goblins are waiting for that moment.”

I nod.

“Okay, a small group, then. What would that entail?”

“...Four riders, I suppose. Six, maybe, depending on how heavy the markers are. It would slow them down, and hammering it into the ground would take—”

“What if Durene carried the markers? She could probably drive them into the earth with her bare hands.”

Wiskeria gulps and I hear the noise.

“That could work. But it would be dangerous.”

“You’ve said that. *How* dangerous?”

“I wouldn’t risk it, your majesty. Why—”

“Give me odds, Wiskeria. Solid odds. Out of ten.”

She pauses.

“...Four in ten odds they’re attacked, sire. If they move fast enough, if they keep in the open.”

“Good. In that case—do it. Seven points around Riverfarm, evenly spaced as possible. A perimeter. Four miles away from the village, each one.”

“But—”

“I’m not discussing this, Wiskeria. Do it. Take Durene with you to make it quicker and however many people you need to feel safe, but get it done.”

I turn away from Wiskeria abruptly. My faith in her is...weakened. I thought I could trust her. She wasn’t the spy, but she did place us in danger with the Mossbear. That might have been her doing, not Sacra’s. That she didn’t come clean about it bothers me most.

And Sacra. It seems like she was one of Magnolia’s spies, someone who could pose as a Silver-rank team leader when needed. Was her hiring Wiskeria really due to them being old friends? Or was the entire team in on it?

I don’t know. I only know that she’s gone and the Goblins are my biggest threat. I stand in the village and hear the Windfrozen Riders—and Durene depart.

My heart is beating too quickly. I’m taking a huge risk. I’m gambling their lives—and Durene’s on this. I wouldn’t risk her for anything, but I have to do this. It has to work.

Prost hurries up to me, worried.

“Emperor Laken, I heard you’d ordered a group to take Jelov’s decorated poles out and place them in the dirt. It’s not my place to say, but —”

“Then don’t, Prost. I know what I’m doing.”

He falls silent. I wait, feeling seconds turn into hours, at least in my mind I feel a twinge of guilt, realizing Prost is standing with me. I’d like to explain. However, I might be wrong.

No, I can’t be wrong. But nothing else has been going my way of late. Goblins. Spies. It’s all out of control. I have only this idea—hell, it’s not even *mine*! I just want it to work. It has to work. Otherwise—

Thump.

There’s a feeling in my chest. I pause; put a hand to my chest. I can sense Prost looking at me worriedly in silence.

Thump. I feel it, and scraping dirt. It’s coming in the direction the riders and Durene left. A sensation, far away. Miles away, in fact. I’d bet anything it was exactly four miles.

“One.”

I can feel it being hammered into the ground in the distance. It’s like a beacon in my mind. Prost looks at me.

“What’s that sire?”

“One, Prost. Wait for it.”

It’s...twenty minutes or more before I feel the *thump* again. Can you travel four miles in twenty minutes? You can if you’re running with a horse. And Durene—I’ll bet she can run pretty damn fast too.

“Two.”

Prost looks at me, silent. But he’s catching on. It’s about the same time when I feel it again. Three points now, each one in the distance. One to my east, another southeast, another almost directly south...

“Three.”

Forming a circle. It goes on. Now one to my west. It takes a while. But then—

“Four.”

North, now. Prost is waiting and so am I. My heart is pounding. North—north west.

“Five.”

Two left to go. I wait. The next *thump* makes my body shake. I feel Prost steady me. The earth shifts. I feel it—

“Si—”

I stagger. I’m not aware of Prost catching me, shouting for Wiskeria. I only know it’s happened.

Six. That was the magic number. I feel it. A huge area of land, marked by six points, opens up in my head. Suddenly, I can *see* the entire world encompassed in that space.

That’s right. The markers. The pieces of wood Jelov worked so hard on. They’re in the ground now, and they demarcate a rough hexagon, slanted oddly near the north side, but circular, around my village.

Six points. Six markers made of wood, bearing my symbol, claiming this land as my own. Now the points are connected in my head, and the wide area they encompass is suddenly *there*. I can stretch my senses beyond the limits of the village.

I sense the forest, still covered with snow, the melting water as it drips off of a branch under the light from the sun, the Mossbear slumbering in its cave, a squirrel hibernating in a tree, worms wriggling under the mud near a rock—

And the Goblins. There they are. Hiding in the forest, a group of them armed with bows watching the adventurers and Durene racing across an open road to the last point. They’re hidden in the trees, waiting in ambush. I see a Goblin raising a bow, aiming at Durene’s back, an arrow drawn.

No! I draw breath, sightless, seeing it in my mind as Wiskeria asks me what’s happening. But my soul, my very being is somewhere else. I’m with Durene, watching her pant and carry the last marker, exhausted from her rapid pace. My heart is with hers, and its life rests on the arrow the Goblin sights down. He’s aiming at her head. I shout.

“Stop!”

The word echoes. It freezes the people around me—and the Goblin. His arm freezes as he’s about to release. He halts—and then curses, looks around. The Goblin sees nothing and looks at Durene, suddenly concerned. His fellows stare at him impatiently. Durene is nearly away.

He hesitates, falters. I say the word again.

“Stop.”

This time the Goblin still moves. He jerks, snarls, draws the arrow to his cheek again. The word doesn’t work on him fully.

It’s a pushing, a mental shove. That’s what effect my [Emperor]’s command has. I can see the Goblin have to brace itself in some way as I demand he stops, but he can keep moving now he knows what’s coming. This time he aims at one of the adventurers.

“Stop!”

The hesitation is barely a flicker. The Goblin releases the arrow, howling with triumph and fury. The arrow streaks after the adventurers, strikes a horse’s side. The horse and rider go down and I see Durene dragging both away. The adventures are retreating. The Goblins get ready to swarm them.

There’s a huge Hobgoblin, all fat and muscle, holding a longsword and signaling the Goblins to move in. One of two. The other Hobgoblin is closer, watching the village from afar with a group of Goblins patiently waiting in a forest clearing.

But this Hob. He’ll try to kill Durene. I see it in his eyes. So I whisper a command to him.

“Leave this place. Go far away and never come back.”

He starts as well. I sense his foot take a step away from Durene, and then he jerks it back. The command was almost completely ineffectual. But it gives Durene a chance to put more ground between her and the Goblins. And now he’s distracted.

The Hob casts around. He knows something is happening, but can’t see what. He’s wary, rightly so. He snarls something at the Goblin archer and I

see the two conferring. The Hobgoblin turns his head, stares with narrowed eyes the way the riders and Durene have gone.

Towards the village. Towards me.

In my mind, I can see Durene and the riders running back towards the village. They abandon the last marker; they have to abandon the horse too. The [Rider] slits her horse's throat, sobbing, rather than let it be taken alive by the Goblins. They come back.

And the Goblins do too. I see them streaming through the forest, some stopping to crap in the snow, others laughing, fingering weapons. The Hob snarls at them and they keep silent.

Now both Hobs are together. They gesture towards the village, the one with the sword arguing with the other. A decision is reached.

By the time Durene reaches the village, practically collapsing with exhaustion, I see it. The Goblins move out. A small group breaks away from the larger mass, circles around the village. The Goblins begin sharpening weapons, chattering excitedly. I sense their intent, see it in the way they move.

They have nets. Bundles of dry wood. They mean to capture some of the villagers and torch this place when they leave. The Hobgoblin is shouting at them, ordering them—

“—Laken? *Laken!* Please, get up!”

Someone's shaking me. Someone's holding me, pleading with me. I hear a voice I love, feel sweaty, callused palms, smell Durene—

I don't open my eyes. There's really no point. But suddenly, I'm back in my body, lying in Prost's house, as Durene shakes me and Prost, Wiskeria, and all the villagers who can fit in the room hover around me. I can sense them all, hear their distressed voices. Gamel is clutching the bedframe so hard I can sense the wood splintering a bit.

“Durene? Stop shaking me, please.”

“Oh! Thank goodness!”

She sweeps me up into a hug that nearly kills me. I gasp, and Wiskeria and Prost manage to make Durene let go. I sit up, breathless, and look

around. Prost hovers around me, worried.

“Your majesty? What happened? One second you were speaking, the next, you fell over!”

“I’m fine, Prost. I told you I had a plan. Thanks for catching me. Now... I need to get up.”

“Are you sure? If you need to rest—”

“Up, Prost. And then you, Wiskeria, and Beniar will meet me...right here. Everyone else can get out. Durene can stay if she wants. We’re going to end this thing with the Goblins right *now*.”

This is what an [Emperor] sees. Three people, a young man, an older young woman, and an older man standing around a dining room table in a house still bearing the marks of the avalanche. I sit in a chair, holding a mug of tea.

And see my empire. Now it’s a huge plot of land, not just a village. I see forests and hills, animals, grass and trees buried under the snow, and all things in between. This is mine.

And there are trespassers on my land. Thanks to my senses, I can count them all. I can see where they are. And I know we’re in trouble.

“Sixty four Goblins? And two Hobs?”

Wiskeria looks at me. Credit to her, after all she’s been through she can still focus. Even more credit—after hearing what I’ve said, her voice is only slightly shaking.

I nod.

“And you’re...sure, your majesty? Absolutely sure?”

“Absolutely. I may have miscounted—”

“Oh?”

“It may be higher. They move around and I lose track. But it’s at least sixty four. At least.”

She pales. I turn my attention from her, to the fidgeting young man. Beniar stares at me.

“How can you know this, your majesty?”

I shrug.

“I can see them. The markers you placed claimed this land as mine. I can sense everything that goes on in my empire, including how the Goblins are moving. It’s a Skill that [Emperors] have. Or maybe just a function of my class. I don’t know.”

Beniar’s open-mouthed, staring at me. So is Prost, but Wiskeria’s focused on what I’ve said about the Goblins.

“Sixty. That’s...too many. We’ve twelve of the Trackers and seven of Beniar’s riders. We’ll be overwhelmed. And two Hobs—each one’s as dangerous as the Mossbear. More dangerous because they can think.”

Beniar nods. He strokes at the stubble around his chin, sounding worried.

“Sixty four. I uh—if they’re not trained warriors—and if they are—well, it’s doable if we can catch them off guard, right, Wiskeria?”

He turns hopefully to the [Witch]. She nods with less conviction and looks at me.

“Do you know where they are, your majesty? We could ambush them and whittle their forces down. I have a few spells I could use if I had the time...”

I wince. Here’s the bad part. I shake my head as Prost turns, sharpening a kitchen knife with a whetstone.

“They are coming. I—tipped them off.”

Prost’s hand slips. I sense the blood and hear him curse. Beniar starts and Wiskeria gets up—

“It’s nothing. Your majesty, if they’re coming, we’re doomed. At least, that’s what I understand from my own class and the looks on these

adventurer's faces."

"Perhaps. But if we run, they'll hunt us down, Prost. If we can fight them back...there is a chance. We've been training the villagers, and there are over a hundred and fifty of us."

"Not all warriors, sire. Many children, folk too old or injured to fight, and most've never fought anything before. A far cry from a seasoned Goblin [Warrior]."

"Yes. I know."

Silence. I can sense the adventurers and Prost looking at each other. But there's no options available. Wiskeria clears her throat.

"We can rely on the palisades, block off the main street now we know they're coming. I'll prepare spells; see what the best area to fight in is."

"I'll do the same."

Beniar springs to his feet. I raise a hand and he stops.

"There's something else."

I detected a group of Goblins splitting off from the main force, circling around the village. They're clearly trying to flank us. When I tell Wiskeria that, she nods.

"How many?"

"Twenty...three. Including one of the Hobs. That leaves fewer Goblins to attack from the front, I guess."

"But more to hit us where we least want them. I have a proposal, your majesty. If we let the Windfrozen Riders handle them—"

"*What?*"

Beniar's outraged. Wiskeria freezes him with a cold stare.

"You have seven people in your group, Beniar. Seven, including you. I doubt you could fight off that many alone. We'll give you some other villagers who can use bows."

"Yes, but—that leaves the Trackers and villagers to hold off forty Goblins and a Hob!"

“We’ll have to do it. We can’t risk being attacked from two sides. If you can finish off your group, you can help us. But we *can’t* let ourselves be overrun.”

Wiskeria’s in charge. She’s taking command in this moment and no one, including me is about to stop her. I can’t see the map she’s looking at, and she understands more of war than I do.

However, my input matters. I talk with Wiskeria as Beniar goes out to let his party know what they’ll be doing. Prost is already organizing a barricade.

I can sense her glancing at me from time to time. After a while, she breaks off from asking me what the Goblins are using as weapons—swords and spears, mainly with a few axes for good measure—and speaks quietly.

“I...wanted to apologize, your majesty.”

“For what, exactly?”

“For casting a spell on you. For not telling you about the Mossbear fur. For Odveig...all of it. I know that if I were in any other kingdom, the punishment for any of these things might be my life. I can only beg for forgiveness.”

I grimace.

“I put you in a bad spot, Wiskeria. I’m still angry about the Mossbear fur, but I understand that was a precaution.”

“Yes. I was actually trying to drive it off before you did. I didn’t understand *why* it was so furious—I suppose Odveig might have done something to it.”

“Well, her actions are not your fault, Wiskeria.”

“But they are. She is—was—our team leader. Because she did all these things...”

“Tell you what, Wiskeria. We’ll sort out blame after all of this. But if you fight and put your life on the line with all of us, I’ll consider that a very strong endorsement of your innocence. Deal?”

“Yes, your majesty.”

“Now tell me how likely it is you think we’ll survive.”

For a while she’s silent. Wiskeria traces the map and I hear the rustle of paper.

“Truly? We’ve no [Strategist] or [Leader] and neither do they.”

“I’m an [Emperor].”

“Yes, but—I apologize, your majesty. However, you’ve not said you have any direct combat skills. Without those, the battle remains as it is.”

“I see. You’re correct. In that case...”

“We have Durene. She might be as strong as a Hob, but she’s never fought before. We outnumber the Goblins, but only with the villagers who are as yet inexperienced. And these Goblins are trained, deadly. It will come down to your people, sire. They would win no matter what the odds if they were without fear—”

“But they are afraid.”

“Yes. And they will die, and see their friends and family dying. They’ll pay the cost in blood. And if they break and run—”

“We die.”

“Yes.”

Wiskeria takes my hand for a moment. Her hands are cold and clammy. I squeeze her hand gently.

“Well then, I suppose it’s my job to make sure that doesn’t happen.”

I sense her smile weakly. We say little more. The village is alive with fear, with tension. But also, strangely, a bit of certainty. After so much waiting, the Goblins are finally coming. For all of us, there’s some relief in that finality.

I don’t want to die here. Wiskeria and I part ways after a while. I want to be with Durene for the hours before night, when we think they’ll strike, and she has work to do.

“Emperor Laken? May I ask you one question?”

Wiskeria stops me before I go. I turn.

“Yes?”

She hesitates.

“I’ve wanted to know this the entire time. You—you’re truly an [Emperor], aren’t you?”

“Yes. I am.”

“In that case...how did you become one? Were you born to it? Are you from some distant land?”

I have to laugh softly.

“I am from a distant land. One you’ve never heard of, Wiskeria. But I was not born an [Emperor]. In fact, I only became one when I met Durene.”

“What? Then how—?”

“I decided to be one. Because I knew I could be one. Because I’d heard a story about an [Emperor] with no crown. An [Emperor] with no castle. An [Emperor] with a city to live in and not a penny to his name. Beloved by all.”

With that, I leave her. I walk out the door and kiss Durene in the middle of the village. And night falls.

And the Goblins come.

This is the sound of the end. It’s blowing horns, shouting in the woods, and wind howling through the trees. The wind has to howl. It’s only fitting.

It’s the sound of your own teeth chattering as you try to make a speech. It’s the sound of a young man weeping and people around him shouting at the Goblins, roaring as if to drown out the guttural shrieks coming towards them.

It’s the sound of saying goodbye to your loved ones, holding a child’s hand, lying, saying that all will be well. It’s the sound of ‘I love you’, spoken a hundred ways to a hundred people.

It is the sound of Goblins.

They burst out of the woods around midnight. It's a terrible wait, knowing they're coming. When they do come, it's so quick I can barely shout before the alarm is raised.

But we're ready. The Goblins falter a second as they see the barricades made from overturned wagons and spikes driven diagonally into the ground. But on they come. A huge Hob is leading them, sword gleaming in the winter moonlight.

And the Goblins are everywhere. I know there are only forty of them, but they stream across the ground like one mass. I can only imagine what it's like to see all of this and not sense it. I'm standing at the back of the rows of villagers and I think I can hear Wiskeria's heart stop.

But she doesn't falter. As the Goblins approach she shouts and the villagers with bows and the Celestial Trackers loose quarrel after quarrel at the Goblins. They're answered with arrows from the Goblins' bows, and I hear villagers cry out around me.

"To the rear! *More goblins!*"

A shout goes up. I can sense the Hobgoblin's smile, but the trap he's set with his friend cuts both ways. I hear a wild war cry as Beniar and his Windfrozen Riders charge towards the Goblins trying to attack from behind. I pray for him.

And then the Goblins are here. I hear a voice like gravel shrieking and feel helpless. I have a woodcutter's axe with me, but I'm to stay behind the fighting. Everyone insisted. Prost told me privately that he thinks the villagers will flee if I'm killed or wounded.

So I wait. And I see it all.

The first group of Goblins doesn't charge onto the wooden spikes. That would be suicide. They hack at the sharpened points instead, cutting with their weapons and then surge through the gaps, climbing the barricades and fighting with the people jabbing spears and other weapons down at them.

"Celestial Trackers! *On me!*"

Wiskeria screams and throws glowing blue fire at the nearest Goblins. She and the Celestial Trackers rush forwards. Some hang back, loosing

arrows in point-blank archery duels with Goblins.

“For Riverfarm!”

Prost leads the counterattack. He and the villagers keep formation, trying to hold the Goblins at bay. But retreating. The Goblins are expert warriors and they swarm and try to get around the villagers, some going as far as to try and climb the roofs of the houses and leap down on the villagers from above.

“For Laken!”

I hear a different cry, and sense Durene. She’s towering over the other Humans, and the Goblins are reluctant to go near her. She swings her club and they back up. Wiskeria is trading spells with a Goblin in the back wearing war paint—a [Shaman]?

And then I see the huge, fat Goblin towering over the rest. Only it’s not fat, is it? Hobgoblins like this one are round and made of muscle. And he is taller than anyone but Durene. Stronger, too.

The Hob is fighting across from Durene. He’s *smashing* the wooden barricades, sending villagers tumbling off it and opening a hole with pure brute strength. As I watch, he turns and cuts. One of the Celestial Trackers screams and falls, her hand severed at the wrist.

No. I want to cry out, to rush forward, but the villagers are forming a solid mass between me and the Hobgoblin. I look around—there’s a platform the archers are meant to be using, only this one’s lost its archer. I find a young woman on the ground behind it. Dead. There’s an arrow in her throat.

No time to be sick. No time to cry. I stand on the platform. I can’t use a bow. That’s one of the things sight is essential for. But I can use my voice. So I shout.

“I am Laken Godart, [Emperor] of Riverfarm! You are trespassing on my land! Leave or die!”

I’m shouting right at the Hobgoblin. I know he can hear me. He turns—his eyes are glowing, although in my mind they have no color. I shout.

“Halt!”

For a moment he does. Long enough for a villager to attack him with a pitchfork. But the moment of hesitation isn't enough for the young man to capitalize on it. The Hobgoblin twists his body and the tines of the pitchfork break on his armor. He slashes—the young man falls.

“I said, *halt!*”

This time the Hobgoblin gives me a dismissive glance. My voice of command is useless on him. He turns and grins as the Goblins around him shout and drive the villagers back.

Helpless. I feel helpless. Wiskeria is shouting orders and Prost is fighting. Durene swings her mace and Goblins scatter around her. One is too slow. The blow breaks something in the Goblin and it—she—falls.

And I do nothing.

My voice is useless. The Goblins laugh and sneer at my attempts to stop them. I can only shout. My words—

I see them falling. My villagers. They're being pushed back by the Goblins' relentless assaults. And their morale is weakening. Already three of the Trackers have fallen. Wiskeria screams as the [Shaman] hits her with a bolt of energy that scorches her shoulder black.

They are my people and I cannot help them. In this moment, I know it. I see a young man with a hoe cutting at a Goblin, and watch as it ducks beneath the blade, snarling, and stabs into his stomach.

His intestines come out. I see the Goblin duck away as he collapses. I know his name.

Calop, the name of a root. He is mine.

Mine. I pulled him from the ground. I saved his life. They can't take him. He is my subject.

But he fades. I see him sagging, see a young woman clinging to him, trying to pull him up and ward the same Goblin away. He grins and cuts her.

Her name is—is Fulca. I offered her sanctuary. I told her she would be safe.

She falls too. Dying. They're all dying.

My mouth opens silently. You cannot have them. They are mine. My subjects. My people.

Mine.

I don't realize that I've leapt off the archery tower. I'm standing at the backs of the villagers now, shouting.

"Stand and fight! Don't retreat! Don't let them advance a single step!"

They hear me. I can see villagers' heads turning, see them struggling harder. But they are mortal and frail. This is all they can do and spirit is—a Goblin guts a young teenage girl, barely older than a child.

It's not enough. Now I'm screaming at the Goblins, shouting as they laugh in my face.

"You are not worthy of standing on this land. You did not bleed for it. You have not died for it! The people of this village have lived and died here for generations! This is theirs. And mine!"

I point at the Hob. He sees me now and throws a man aside as he cuts towards me.

"I will burn your people to dust. I will hound them from the face of the earth! I swear to you, for every one of my subjects that falls I will take a hundred of your kind as vengeance! *I will not let you take this ground!*"

There's fury in my heart. Something bursting in my mind. I feel something ignite. The Hob is coming. I hear Durene's scream, Prost yelling.

"Kneel, Goblin."

This time the Hob's knees buckle. He pauses and when he looks at me, it's no longer with a smile. He raises his longsword. I have the axe. I raise it.

Someone shoves me aside. The Hob's sword descends and cuts the young man who gets in the way. Gamel blinks at me as the longsword opens up his chest. I see bloody ribs, see his open mouth.

He falls. The Hob turns to me and Durene bellows a challenge. She roars, hurling villagers and Goblins aside and the Hob backs up.

I don't see her collide with the Hob. Gamel's on the ground. He's trying to tell me something. *I tried? Please...?*

I can't hear. I can sense the light leaving him as I try to grip his hand. Not him. I can't let him go. I can't.

I won't.

"Stand up! Don't die! I said, stand up! Gamel!"

He tries. But there's nothing left. He's given it all to me. All. His life fades and I see it flowing out of him. I reach for it. It's not enough. I want more. I demand more. He cannot die yet.

I will not allow it.

"Stop bleeding. Stop. **Stop.**"

It doesn't work. Something in me speaks. I look into Gamel's heart. His soul.

"Stop."

Something—Gamel stares at me. The wound on his chest is gushing blood. It stains the ground. But now the blood stops. Gamel's body jerks. He stares at me. My voice is an echo. Distant. Loud like tempests, terrible. Alien. It rolls and breaks upon the ears of the living. A command.

"Stand up."

His legs move. Weakly. There's not enough strength in him. That's fine. I'll give him more. I rise.

"Stand up, Gamel. You swore to follow me on the graves of your parents. In ice and blood and loss. It is not time for you to die. I need you. *Stand up!*"

His body moves. Gamel rises, the sword in his hand gripped in a pale hand. I turn. There are Goblins fighting with the villagers. They stare at Gamel as he turns towards them, his chest opened, covered in his life's blood.

"Fight!"

Gamel charges. Flames burst from his hand and sear one Goblin's chest. He hacks at another Goblin. They fall back, afraid.

The other villagers are fighting. They see Gamel and falter. But then they hear my voice.

“Fight, people of Riverfarm! Fight, folk of Windrest! Fight! You have sworn yourselves to me! Fight for your [Emperor]!”

I command them. I command their very souls. The wounded rise. Exhausted arms move as if they were fresh. Limbs without strength grapple with their opponents and force them back. My voice is in their ears as the villagers form up, forcing the line of Goblins back. The words come out of me, out of some place in my soul.

“Stand. I see your lives like flames on the sea. You are mine. The water will not touch you. The wind cannot quench your fire. So long as I live, your fates and mine burn together. I do not give you permission to die. So stand—and show me nothing but victory.”

The Goblins hesitate. They have never seen this. An old man with a rake charges them, hacking at faces. He blinds a Goblin with a strike, bites the sharpened points deep into another Goblin’s back. Others stab him, mortal wounds to his chest and throat.

Breathless, he keeps swinging his rake. Heart stopped, he seizes a Goblin and tears at his throat. He keeps moving as he falls, keeps fighting. And he is one. Gamel fights past him, face contorted with rage. Prost runs through a Goblin and keeps running. The villagers *charge* and the Goblins retreat.

Something roars. The Goblins turn and something charges them from behind. The [Shaman] casting spells at the dying witch stops laughing and sees a paw descend. The Mossbear smashes the Goblin flat and bites into a second. It roars, and bites the intruders. Called by a spell. Commanded by an [Emperor].

Two shapes fight amid the Goblins and Humans. Two giants. Durene and the Hobgoblin strike at each other, trading blows. He has a shield to go with his sword and moves with trained grace. She is slow. Her shield is crude, but it blocks his sword.

Yet she is wounded. He’s cut her deeply on the side and along one breast. Now the Hob senses the tide turning. He snarls and swings his sword. Durene sees it coming on her club arm. She does not try to block.

She howls and swings her club. The sword bites deep into her arm, cutting through grey flesh and stopping on bone. The Hobgoblin raises his other arm, his shield. The club falls through the sky and nothing in this world can stop it.

The shield deforms. The arm breaks. The Hobgoblin's head implodes and it falls. Durene turns with his sword still buried in her left arm and roars.

She has forgotten who she is. I have forgotten who I am. A girl reaches out for fury and finds it in her desperation, in her rage.

The Goblins look at her and step back. She looms over them, bleeding, holding her club. They see the part of her the Humans fear. The part of her that has never come out before.

Troll.

Durene roars and swings her club. Two Goblins die. She hammers another one into the ground, dead the moment her weapon touches him. On the hill, an [Emperor] howls and his people rush forwards around the Troll, screaming, fearless.

The Goblins are warriors. Not heroes. They break and flee as they are overrun.

A screaming band of riders rushes out from the village, weapons and armor covered in blood. They charge the Goblins from the side, cutting down Goblins from behind.

Not one escapes. The last is crushed by a massive hand. Durene tears the Goblin's arm from his socket and hurls the body to the ground to stomp on it. In the sudden silence, every head turns.

Like magic, the villagers, the adventurers, and the half-Troll turn to look at a young man. He stands by himself, apart from the fighting. Something is looming in his shadow. He stands like a giant amid the dead, and for a moment his words are bolts of lightning, strings that death cannot cut.

Then it fades. He sags and villagers drop like stones. Laken Godart stares at his hands. They are not covered in blood. They are wet instead.

With tears.

It's over. The Goblins are dead. But it is not over.

There are wounded to attend to. So many. So many dead. In truth, not that many—

Not all. But more fall by the second, whether from exhaustion or mortal injuries, it's impossible to say. Prost carries people to beds, opens healing potion bottles with trembling hands. It's a race against time and some die despite his efforts.

And mine. I open bottles, hand them to people, pour the liquid over wounds and wait for them to close. Some don't. I'm just one person in the village. One person among many that no one speaks to.

No one can look at me. No one speaks to me. I think they're afraid to. I can barely exist myself. I—feel like I was another person for a while. I feel like another man's memories are in my head.

What did I say? Why did I say it? How could I—

I stop and lean against the wall of a house. It's cold. I feel sick. I want to throw up, but I can't. I am their [Emperor]. I gave them the orders. No one else did. I ordered them to fight, and when they were dying, I told them to live.

Because I willed it.

And then I remember Gamel. I find him among the wounded, lying on a cot in the barn. I slow as I see him.

“Gamel?”

“Emperor?”

He stares up at me. I can feel his hands shaking as they try to grip mine. The gaping wound in his stomach is gone. All healed. But the trauma and blood loss can't be healed so easily. He can't stand.

He is hovering at the edge of life and death. He was dead. He was meant to be dead. The wound's closed, but he can't be alive. Like the old man with

the rake. He was still moving afterwards. But though the potion closed his injuries, he never opened his eyes.

“Gamel. I’m sorry.”

“I—was happy to serve. You gave me strength.”

Gamel struggles to talk. I can see something in his eyes, fading away again. I shake my head. Tears.

“I shouldn’t have. I took something from you. I—”

“Wanted to. Give. A ruler is more than a man.”

I stare down at Gamel.

“No. Yes. He is. But I am still sorry.”

It’s not a word. Just a question in his eyes. I sit by Gamel. The words come out of me slowly.

“A ruler can afford to see nothing but pawns and tools or break his heart against his duties. But the mortal, human soul in him must cry out for every injustice he commits. Or he is no ruler, but a monster wearing the same skin. I am both. And I am sorry.”

“Still my [Emperor]. Saved us. I’ll live.”

I smile. My heart is twisting in my chest.

“Yes. You will live. Sleep now, Gamel. Sleep—and rest while I can still let you.”

He closes his eyes. I can’t tell if he’s dying or not. I put my hand on his chest and feel nothing.

I look around. The lines of bodies are long. But I sense many chests rising and falling.

Thirty one dead, forty six wounded. Of that number, eight had wounds that could not be healed with potions. A young man lost three fingers. A wife a leg. One of Beniar’s riders lost an eye. Some should have died from the wounds they took.

But they lived. Because I commanded it. They lived when many should have died.

The Mossbear is gone. It left after eating some of the dead Goblins. I think it was wounded, but not deeply. Wiskeria summoned it from its cave.

A last resort. An emergency measure. That's why she wanted the fur.

These are all numbers I see. In my mind. But it doesn't change reality. I stare at the few people who are upright. Some are still holding their weapons. A shovel, a rake, a frying pan of all things. But they killed with them. The blood is still on some.

I have made warriors of these humble folk. I have turned farmers into killers and taught them what death is. Is there anyone who wouldn't be changed by such an experience? They have killed.

Goblins. They killed Goblins. But Goblins are too much like people. The people of Riverfarm and Windrest will remember this day for the rest of their lives.

Prost finds me kneeling next to Gamel. He takes me away for a moment. When he speaks, it's a simple statement.

"You saved us."

"You saved yourselves."

"No."

He shakes his head.

"You saved *us*. I felt it. When you spoke—"

"I manipulated you. I took away your will. I forced you to—I had no right. Surely you agree."

He shakes his head again. There's pain in Prost's eyes. His wife was the one who lost her leg. But his children are alive. I look into his eyes and see little gratitude. It hurts too much for that. But neither do I see anger or hatred, either.

"Not for us to say, my Emperor. We are yours. We gave all we had to you for our lives, and that of our families. We are sworn to you. Servants, subjects to a ruler. If we wished for freedom, we could only but rebel and break our oaths. We would be damned for that."

"Some oath. What do you get, then?"

“You, lord.”

I look at Prost. He reaches out.

“You. We are yours and you are ours. So it is for every ruler and his people. They are his, or hers. And they belong to their people. One cannot live without the other. For better or worse, they are bound until one is gone.”

“Is it a Skill? Part of my class?”

For the first time in a long while, I see Prost smile. He shakes his head.

“It is not just part of classes and levels. It is the bond we have made. You gave us hope and purpose. You gave us life when the snow buried our home and our families. You pulled us out with your bare hands. How could we not give you everything we have in return?”

He leaves me with that. I go back and find Wiskeria. She’s sobbing over one of her friends. When she sees me she bows her head.

“I don’t know what—I heard you. I felt you. I—I can’t go back to Invrisil after this. I can’t.”

I kneel as she chokes on her words. She looks at me with tears in her eyes.

“Part of me died here. Part of the Celestial Trackers. We’re gone. We put too much of ourselves into that battle.”

Of the Trackers, four out of twelve survived. Of the Windfrozen Riders, five. I look at Wiskeria. At her as she is, raw, grieving. It’s not the time. But there’s nothing else I can give her.

“Wiskeria, I—I’ve misjudged you. You and your group have given—no. Wiskeria, listen to me.”

She looks at me.

“Be my [General].”

I say it softly. She blinks as if she can’t understand. But she’s smart.

“What? How?”

I turn. So many wounded. So many hurt. A battle with no [Strategist] or [Leader]. I look back at her.

“I have...a certain number of positions I can give away as an [Emperor]. Not many positions of nobility; they’re filled. But every ruler needs someone to direct their armies. I’d like that person to be you.”

“Me?”

“You lead the battle. You’ve led a group. No one else can do it. Beniar is too reckless, but you—you could do it.”

“But I’m a [Witch]. I never dreamed of being a [General]. I can’t just give up my class.”

“Be a [Witch], then. Be a [General], too. Be the first [Witch General] the world has ever seen. If that class exists, you’ll have it. If not—I’ll make it for you. But be mine, Wiskeria.”

I hold out my hand to her, in the barn full of grieving voices and death. There isn’t anything else in the world but Wiskeria and me. She stares at my hand, at me.

“Take my hand and walk with me until the world ends or we do.”

Forever passes as we look at each other. There’s still so much we don’t know. But she knows enough of me and I know her. She takes my hand. And it’s done.

I find Durene after the rest of it. She’s crying, holding a friend. I hold her close and feel her shaking. We lie down for a second and hold each other. For a second of rest. Then she gets up to help the wounded again. My [Paladin]. I close my eyes.

[Emperor Level 15!]

[Skill – Empire: Art of the Builder Obtained!]

[Skill – Undying Loyalty Learned.]

Sleep calls. But I hear the voice and know. In my heart. It pulls me up. I stand.

[Undying Loyalty]. A word for what I did. A chance. Just one.

So I sit with Gamel throughout the night. He alone lives. The rest, those who I called back from the grave—

Die.

Day 70

Durene leveled too. That's the upshot of it. Wiskeria became a Level 4 [General] overnight—Prost leveled. I don't think there was one person in the village who didn't level or gain a class, come to that.

There's no work to be done the next day. Just burying the dead and burning the Goblins. I feel like a ghost at times, so little do I speak. There's no need for an [Emperor] to order anything at this moment. I just need to be there so people can see me. To know I'm there.

They still believe in me. They believe in a man who ordered them to fight and die. Because in doing so, I saved them. I cannot forgive myself, but there is nothing to forgive for them.

We are alive. I go on with that knowledge keeping me sane.

Durene and I sit together after the digging is done. The cold ground is rough, but she is tireless. Among her new Skills is [Lesser Endurance].

Now, in the quiet of mourning I finally tell her the truth. She sits cross-legged with me, feeding Frostwing and letting the bird nip her fingers. Frostwing flaps her wings and a feather floats down.

"A [General], a [Steward], a [Paladin]...all of these classes are rare. Special. Stronger than normal classes because they're more important, you could say. Or so my theory goes."

"So that's why you gave it to me."

"Well, that wasn't my idea to begin with. That was...luck."

"Oh. But it's better than other classes?"

"Better than [Warrior]? Yes, I think so. I think some classes are just designed that way, in whatever system this world works off of."

"But that's not fair."

“Of course not. But it has to be this way, Durene. How can a [General] be both a [Strategist], [Warrior], and [Leader] all at the same time? It’s because he—”

“Or she.”

“Thank you. Yes, or she—must be all these things and arguably just as good as an expert in all three fields. There’s a famous [Lord] in the north named Tyrion Veltras. Apparently he’s not only able to manage a vast amount of his lands, but he’s one of the leaders who commands the Human armies when they fight against the Drakes. To me, that sounds like he’s got at least two classes’ worth of Skills packed into one.”

“Oh. That’s good, then. So you’ll give more classes to other people?”

I nod, staring at my hands. This is one of the things I can do for them. I owe them this.

“I’m going to make Gamel my [Knight] if he wants me to. If not—there are other classes I’ve thought of. I have a few good suggestions, too. Wiskeria will offer the rank of [Captain] to Beniar to start with, and if I need to, I’ll give him a higher rank. If he doesn’t like that, I’ll see if he wants to wear armor. If there’s a [Cataphract] class, I’d love to see if his [Riders] could obtain it by wearing armor.”

Durene nods. She stares across the village, at the churned ground, still stained in places, where the fighting happened. She feels at her arm where the sword cut her.

“So how do you know all this, Laken? Claiming lands with markers, giving all these classes out—did you think of it yourself?”

“No. Actually, I...”

I break off and look around. But no one’s nearby to listen. Still, prompted by some hunch, I lean over to Durene. She obligingly bends her head down.

“I...was given this advice by someone. Let’s call it some insider advice. Ah...you don’t know what I mean by that, do you, Durene?”

“Nope.”

“My...informant, let’s call him, was rather strange. He seemed to know exactly how a lot of things would turn out and he knew a lot about my class. He admitted as much. So I’ve used a lot of his suggestions—”

“Like making Mister Prost a [Steward]? And turning Wiskeria into a [General]?”

“And the trick with the totem poles—I mean, markers. Yeah. It’s a bit odd *how* much was exactly like he said. I was wary about taking all the advice, but it was free, and there’s a saying where I come from...”

I trail off for a second. Durene nudges me.

“What? What’s the saying?”

“Oh, ‘don’t look a gift horse in the mouth’.”

She shifts and I hear her voice rumbling in confusion as we sit together.

“Why wouldn’t you look one in the mouth? It could be dangerous. What if it was a Dresh Horse? You’d be sorry for not checking, then!”

I have to laugh at that. Trust Durene to come up with a practical answer to a silly folk saying.

“What’s a Dresh—never mind. I get it. And you’re right. But I can’t help but think someone’s on our side out there. Or at least, we’re getting help because it suits someone for the moment.”

“Okay, but when did you meet him? I never saw—”

“I’m not around you all the time, Durene. In fact, I met him in Invril. While I was there.”

“Really? But—”

“I’ll tell you all about it. Later. Hold on, someone’s coming.”

I stand up, suddenly worried. Someone *is* coming. Someone on horseback. Odveig? Sacra?

It’s not her. Instead, a man on horseback rides into the village, staring at the Goblin bodies and asking for me. He’s escorted to me by the villagers, some of whom are holding weapons.

I’m not worried. The man showed Prost his Runner’s Seal. Some use horses. And he has something for me. The man clears his throat a few times

and I hear him speak quite nervously as he half-bows in my direction.

“I have a letter addressed to an...[Emperor]? Emperor Laken of Riverfarm?”

“That’s me.”

I have no Runner’s Seal, nor any way to prove who I am. Nevertheless, the City Runner doesn’t hesitate for a moment to hand the letter over. It smells faintly of...orchids? Perhaps. Something close to that, a delicate perfume. Durene’s murmuring tells me the parchment is rich. There’s no name on the letter, just a wax seal.

A letter to an [Emperor]. I break the wax seal and open the letter. It’s short. I have to have Wiskeria read it out loud to me.

“To the esteemed [Emperor] Laken Godart of Riverfarm, I am humbly...”

Looks like it’s a greeting from a [Lady] Rie who lives in Invisil. She greets me, invites me to her estate which is only a few miles away, offers me her congratulations...I listen to Wiskeria read through the letter, barely able to process it at this time.

“Well. She gave this letter to you, did she?”

The City Runner coughs nervously.

“Her manservant did, mil—your majesty. However, this— isn’t the only letter.”

“What?”

“That is the first letter, ah, your majesty. I have three more.”

He has three more letters, two from [Merchants] and one from a [Lord]. I hold them in my hands and sense the Runner fidget.

“Would you like to send a return message? That service has been paid for by each sender.”

“I’ll consider it. Please, stay for a while and allow me time to decide. Unless you’re busy?”

“No your majesty! My time has been paid for. I will wait wherever you please.”

“My [Steward] will find you a spot. And something hot. I will deliberate by myself.”

I wander away from the City Runner and hear him asking what happened. I wonder what Prost will tell him. Myself, I step away from the village and sit on a rock, brushing the snow off of it.

So much has happened. And this is just the latest development. It’s mind boggling. Insane.

“Strange. I can’t believe it.”

I whisper the words out loud. I stare at the letters, sniff the perfume. Each one addressed to me. All coming at once. From [Lords] and [Ladies], no less.

“It’s all happening like he said. *Exactly* like he said.”

I don’t know what to think. My head is whirling, my heart still bleeds. I look back towards my village and raise my head to the sky. Here it is. My empire. My people have bought it in blood and I am bound to it now.

My lands. My people. My love. All things start here. I open the next letter with my thumb.

“Well then. Let’s begin.”

After a second, I look around. I wander back into the village and raise my hand. Everyone looks at me.

“Hey, can someone read this to me?”

4.24

It was going to be an important day. Ivolethe felt it, just like she felt the rays of the sun warm her frozen body slightly. She could sense...there were no words for what she sensed. The English language had no words for it, because Humans had only five senses, and perhaps a few others that were more instinctual and sometimes slightly magical.

A proper comparative would be that Ivolethe tasted the sense of foreboding and premonition on the air and felt déjà vu creeping over her while she simultaneously smelled, heard, and thought of all these sensations as well. It was the feeling of destiny, of fate.

Contrary to what Ryoka Griffin feared, Frost Faeries could not in fact tell the future. They could, however, predict the future, but that was a skill most beings had. Humans could do it. Less well than the fae, but they *could* do it.

It was easy. Show a Human an apple and most would agree that it would fall when dropped. Some might suspect the apple would explode, defy gravity, or commit to some other miraculous feat, but insanity lurks within all species. By and large, Humans could predict the future in simple ways like this.

They could see the apple and know it would fall. However, Ivolethe and her kind were different. The fae could see the apple and know what would happen if it was caught, what would happen if it landed, and what would happen if an arrow shot it out of the air during an archery competition.

They could predict what would happen *after* the apple fell, but they couldn't see the whole of the apple's fate. Just more of it than most. Where mortals saw only the road in front of them, faeries could see the crossroads.

It didn't mean they knew everything. But Ivolethe could see strands of destiny weaving and changing each other. She could sense...peculiarities and moments in time that mattered.

And today, a *lot* of these threads were coming together. So many, and the ones that were already moving were pulling the rest. Because of course, destiny was connected. How could it not be?

So today would be momentous for many people in this small part of the world. It would be special. Ivoethe didn't question the coincidence that pulled together so many events at once; she sometimes thought that reality liked such things. Special things should be special.

It could have been the work of a god as well, of course. Immortal beings were all about important days and destiny. But in this world, such an occurrence would be impossible. Ivoethe knew this. The gods were dead. And they had better stay that way.

The Frost Faerie sighed as the sun rose a bit. She could hear a Gnoll child flopping around her room, waking up to the smell of food as she ran over a young woman's face. Ryoka Griffin groaned and Ivoethe smiled and flew away from Ryoka's windowsill.

Today was going to be important. She flew into the Wandering Inn's kitchen and stole a huge sausage link and some garlic. Even faeries liked something to eat while watching.

Ryoka knew it was going to be a bad day when she woke up. She opened her eyes and knew something was wrong.

There was nothing supernatural about this premonition. Ryoka had lived through too many days like this not to remember.

It was the feeling of things going wrong. It was the sensation in her mind of the sun going out. On days like this, Ryoka couldn't help but feel angry and unhappy.

It had been a while since she felt like this. Back home, on Earth, Ryoka could go for months without days like this. Other times it was a never-

ending week of bad days. And oddly, it always felt like the world seemed to agree with Ryoka's mood.

There was a large, brown beetle with a speckled exoskeleton crawling on her toothbrush. Ryoka stared at it for a long time as it crawled over the fine bristles and investigated the insides of her runner's backpack. It was a fitting start to her morning.

She flicked the beetle off her brush and then tossed it out of the window. Then the Asian girl determinedly spread the foul toothpaste—a blend of sage, salt, pepper and other herbs Octavia mixed up and sold in small jars—and brushed her teeth with her toothbrush.

She took extra-long to brush her teeth just to show the damn beetle what was what. Then Ryoka remembered she hadn't had breakfast.

"Fuck."

She made her way downstairs, trying not to scowl that openly. But her mood had followed her. It lived in her mind. It was a blackness creeping in her thoughts.

"Good morning, Ryoka! Would you like some pancakes? They're hot and we have honey!"

A smiling Lyonette greeted Ryoka. The tall girl grunted at her. The little devil sitting on her shoulder made her shake her head. Just to be contrary.

"No pancakes. I'll have the cinnamon muffins Erin made a few days ago."

"Oh? Sure! I'll heat them up. It'll be a moment. And you want—"

"Milk. Thanks."

That was the thing about Erin's inn. Ryoka could order a steak Erin had seared to perfection five days ago and have it fresh and hot in moments. The hot, warm muffins with a side of honey and milk made the clouds around Ryoka lift for a bit. Then Lyonette came back and showed her Apista.

Ryoka recoiled in her chair as she came face to face with two black, fragmented eyes and a massive, furry insect's head. She backed up and realized it was only massive for a bee. Apista the bee was a bee twice the size of Ryoka's hand, clinging quietly to Lyonette's arm and fanning its wings.

"Isn't she amazing? I have a lesser bond with her, and she listens to everything I say!"

Lyonette beamed as if a bug crawling on her shirt was something to be proud of. Ryoka took one look at the bee and decided to ask Octavia about what kind of poisons she sold. Preferably powders. A nice can of Raid would be acceptable too.

"Okay. Good. Please get it away from me."

Lyonette did, looking somewhat hurt. However, the sight of the giant bee crawling over her arm was frightening enough at a distance, let alone up close. Ryoka eyed the bee's stinger.

"It looks like a queen bee. Are you trying to start a hive or something?"

"No—it's just a pet. I really didn't want to keep it at first but...it grew on me, you know?"

"I see. Can you take it somewhere else while I eat? I don't usually share my meals with insects."

After Apista was gone, Ryoka looked around and found Mrsha was busy harassing Zel Shivertail before he left the inn. He was always in the city doing something. The Gnoll was trying to pin down his tail and having no luck. Zel could lift Mrsha's entire body up with his muscular tail. For some reason, seeing Mrsha enjoying herself with someone else annoyed Ryoka.

"She'd just annoy you if she was here. Think, idiot."

Ryoka smacked herself in the head. That was the thing. She could tell when her mood was bad and she did try to account for it. Well, she tried in this world.

But while Ryoka could tell what was coming, she could never realize when the snap was coming, when the bile rose up and came out of her mouth. When Lyonette gave her a muffin sans bee, Ryoka glanced around to look where it had gone. Apista was calmly eating from a bowl on a table, watched warily by some of the regular customers and hungrily by Bird.

That was another thing. Bird was now a permanent fixture in Erin's inn. He didn't say much and sat on the roof where the third floor and new wing were slowly being constructed. But there were also several Drakes and Gnolls who had decided Erin's inn was a good place to have breakfast.

Right now Ryoka didn't want any company. She unsubtly glared at a Drake who was sitting across from her table, eying the Ashfire Bee queen warily. And meanwhile, Erin had just edged out of the kitchen carrying a pot that was shaking of its own volition. Ryoka stared at it. Lyonette coughed.

"Um, Ryoka? Are you okay?"

"Awesome. Great. What the hell's in the pot?"

There was something disturbing about Erin. It was that when you got to know her, the innkeeper of the Wandering Inn never did normal things. In any other person, Ryoka might have assumed the small pot with the shaking lid was...something explainable. With Erin, Ryoka immediately suspected the worst.

"It's a, uh, slime."

"A what."

"A slime. Remember when Erin was talking about healing slimes?"

"No."

As it turned out, Ryoka was one of the few people Erin *hadn't* told about her idea to make a slime out of a healing potion. Lyonette told Ryoka how she'd cajoled Typhenous and Octavia into helping her create one.

"And they did it? They went along with that insane idiot's—just like that?"

“It’s not hard, apparently. It’s just a mana stone and a bit of existing slime. Apparently they can create themselves. Erin made one out of water to see if it would work first.”

“That stupid—*Erin!*”

Erin came over, beaming and holding the small pot. She opened her mouth.

“Hey Ryoka, guess what—”

“A slime. Why the hell did you do it, Erin?”

The other girl looked put out. She stared at Lyonette, who mimed an apology and scooted away to help Drassi wait the tables. Erin put the pot down on the table and took off the lid. Ryoka had a glimpse of a mostly transparent blob slowly rising from the pot, questing around with part of itself. She slammed the lid down.

“Aw! Ryoka!”

“Are you insane? Why do you think creating a monster is a good idea?”

“It’ll be cool! Lyonette has a pet, so I thought I could get one. Besides, did you hear about my idea to make healing slimes? We could feed it water and mana and get infinite healing potions!”

Ryoka ground her teeth together.

“Erin, *no*. This is exactly like the Rags situation. And Toren! Haven’t you learned anything from the past?”

At that, Erin’s smile vanished.

“What do you mean? This isn’t—Rags was cool.”

“She started her own tribe and started ambushing travelers on the road, Erin. She nearly killed *me* the first time I met her.”

“Yeah, but—she’s innocent, Ryoka. And she’s smart. She’s not like Toren at all.”

Ryoka let that go for the moment. She scowled at Erin. This conversation had been a long time coming. Why did it have to be today it happened?

“Toren? We should have talked about him a while ago, Erin. He was a monster and he didn’t listen to Pisces’ spells or your orders. That much is true, but *you* were also the problem. You never realized he could think, that he had free will, did you? I warned you. Didn’t I tell you about Frankenstein?”

Erin’s smile was long gone at this point. She sat down.

“Yeah. But I didn’t think he could *think*. He’s undead! He was undead.”

“And that’s a slime. A living thing. How long before it gets upset you’re keeping it in a pot—”

“I was going to build a larger place to keep it!”

“—Keeping it prisoner and trying to harvest it, and decides to kill someone? And what was that about healing potions? You want to do what, lick its body now and then? Scoop out its insides whenever you have a cut? Doesn’t that sound a bit like cruelty?”

Ryoka stared at Erin. The other girl wasn’t prepared for this, but she was now on the defensive. And getting angry.

“Typhenous said that slimes don’t feel pain! Or think, really. Why are you so grumpy today?”

“I’m grumpy because this seems like another mistake that’s going to cause trouble for everyone, that’s why! Typhenous is a [Mage] and an adventurer, Erin. He’d blast a hole in a Goblin’s head as soon as look at one.”

“Yeah, but—he’s still right when he’s right, right?”

The Runner girl didn’t dignify that with a response. Erin scowled at her. She suddenly seized the pot.

“Look, it’s just a slime. It’s not dangerous, it’s *small*! See?”

She brought it up right to Ryoka's face so Ryoka could see inside and tilted it to her. Ryoka saw what looked like plain old tap water swirling around in the pot for a moment. Then the fluid inside grew decidedly *non-Newtonian* and leapt onto her face.

Ryoka screamed. It was like being splashed by water, but without the splash. Suddenly, she was choking as water clung to her face and shoulders, trying to cover her head.

"*Mmfh! Getr off!*"

"Oh no! Ryoka!"

Erin tried to grab the water, but her hands passed right through the slime. Ryoka felt herself choking—drowning. She staggered back and shook her head. The slime lost whatever grip it had and splattered onto the floor. It formed into a blob and was immediately scooped up into Erin's pot.

"Are you okay, Ryoka?"

Everyone was staring at her. Ryoka swayed. She put one hand up to her mouth as Mrsha ran over, looking distressed.

"I think I swallowed some of it."

Ryoka felt something *squiggling* down her throat. She was immediately sick.

Six minutes later Ryoka sat at the same table. The vomit was gone, the slime was in the kitchen with a very heavy rock weighing down the lid, and Erin was sitting across from her. Both girls were angry at this point. Ryoka because she'd nearly been drowned and Erin because of what Ryoka had said to her afterwards.

"You've got to get rid of it."

"You mean, kill it."

“That’s the general implication, yes.”

“No.”

“Why not?”

Erin hesitated. She looked around—Zel had left, the Gold-rank adventurers were gone, the Horns of Hammerad were in Celum looking to see if there was any work to be had there, and only the objectionable Drake Ryoka had seen this morning was still around. Finding no inspiration, Erin could only shrug.

“I don’t kill things if I can. Duh. Killing’s bad, m’kay?”

She paused and grinned expectantly. Ryoka’s face remained stony. Erin waited, and then grinned again.

“Hey Ryoka, did you get the reference? See, that was a reference to South Park—”

“I got it. If killing’s so bad, why are you feeding and housing a bunch of Gold-rank adventurers? They kill things all the time.”

“Well, those are monsters—”

“Like the fucking slime.”

“That’s different. They kill really *bad* monsters that are threatening people. Not slimes that accidentally got on someone’s face.”

“Oh? Bad monsters? You mean like Goblins. Like the Goblin Lord’s army, and Rags’ tribe, come to think of it. I suppose they’ll kill all those Goblins and things will be great, won’t they?”

The other girl stared at Ryoka.

“No. No one’s killing Goblins. I put a sign up.”

“The one buried by snow? Good job.”

“Hey Lyonette? Lyonette, get a shovel and—”

“Shut up, Erin. What good is a sign going to do? For that matter, mind telling all the victims of the Goblin Lord’s army that they shouldn’t kill

Goblins? I'm sure that'll go down *wonderfully*."

What was she doing? Ryoka remembered the last fight she'd had with Erin. It hadn't gone well. But there was a feeling in the air now. Erin glared at Ryoka.

"The sign stays."

"Why? So we can all get killed when some actually dangerous Goblins come around?"

"I'm sure that when the evil Goblins are marching around and being... uh, evil, no one's going to worry about my sign. It stays because I don't believe *all* Goblins are evil."

"Right. Some of them are 'just' bandits. Name one Goblin—"

"Rags."

"—One Goblin who *hasn't* tried to hurt or kill you at some point."

Erin hesitated.

"There was this big Hobgoblin that Rags brought one time."

"Right after the Goblin Lord's army tried to kill me and—"

Ryoka broke off, saw Mrsha sitting on a table and playing with a wooden spinning top.

"—And did other things which I'm sure I remember. What's your excuse there?"

Erin stared at Mrsha and shook her head.

"None. They're bad and if they die that's...that's how it has to be. But Rags was different."

"How?"

The innkeeper poked at the spotless table, speaking quietly and then meeting Ryoka's eyes.

“Rags was small. She only wanted to survive. She did bad things, but she wasn’t a monster. She deserved a chance. Just a chance.”

“Sounds like she took that chance to do more ‘bad things’.”

“Maybe. But she’s gone. You didn’t see how Relc treated her, Ryoka! He kicked her and tried to hurt her!”

“For good reason, it sounds like.”

“Oh come on. All Goblins are bad? That’s racism—”

“No, that’s practicality in a world where making a mistake gets you *killed*, Erin.”

“This is about the slime, isn’t it?”

“Yes! It nearly got me! What happens if it crawls out of its pot and finds you asleep? Or Mrsha?”

The Gnoll cub’s ears pricked up. Erin looked at Mrsha, horrorstruck, and then at Ryoka. She wavered, and then got up. She came back with the bumping pot and took off the lid. The slime slowly oozed over the sides. It would have been fascinating, magical to watch if it didn’t make Ryoka so wary.

Erin stared at the clear blob, slightly tainted by a bit of the vomit it had absorbed from Ryoka. Apparently slimes weren’t picky about what they picked up. Ryoka stared at it with deep distrust.

“Fine.”

She pushed the slime out of the pot. It seemed reluctant to go this time. It swirled around on the table. Now Ryoka could see a single part of it that wasn’t fluid. It was a bobbing stone, a shimmering little blue gem hovering around the slime’s center.

Erin sighed.

“They don’t feel pain. And they’re really stupid. But I still feel bad.”

She reached into the slime. It immediately began flowing up her arm. Erin ignored that and quickly plucked the gem out of the slime. It tried to

resist, clinging to the stone, but Erin was too quick and strong. The instant the gem left the slime's body completely it collapsed. Water sloshed over the table, drenching Ryoka and Erin's lower halves.

"What the *hell*?"

Ryoka stared at the remains of the slime as Lyonette rushed out of the kitchen with a towel. Erin showed her the shining gem. It still had bits of water stuck to it.

"Slime core. It's this crystal, see? A mana crystal that's got...slime stuff all over it. It can't do much this small, though. It needs to be at least the size of an apple before it'll move around. But the slime stuff is still part of the slime. They're like a microbe-thing, I think. A fungus, maybe."

"Amoebas that reproduce and join together when exposed to mana?"

"Yup."

Erin put the stone on the table and didn't quite meet Ryoka's eyes. She spoke to Ryoka's right ear instead.

"I'll make a very small healing slime. I'll keep it safe, and *if* it seems violent or dangerous in any way I'll destroy it."

Ryoka sat back. She was hungry again. But she didn't feel like having breakfast twice.

"Well, well. Aren't we hypocritical. Killing stuff's bad, m'kay? Except when you want to experiment. Then it's fine to make life and destroy it."

Erin's head snapped up. She and Ryoka locked gazes and Lyonette desperately tried to get in the way with her body while mopping up the mess.

A howl punctured the silence. It came from a Gnoll's voice and from outside. Ryoka and Erin leapt to their feet. They ran outside and Ryoka saw Mrsha. She was running and a leathery, brown-green creature was attacking her.

It was a bird, a scaled beast. A pterodactyl in almost all respects. It was twice Mrsha's size and it was swooping at Mrsha as the Gnoll child howled

and tried to run for the inn. But the bird wouldn't let her. The dino-bird—the Razorbeak grasped at Mrsha's fur and flapped its wings as Mrsha struggled and bit and clawed at it. It was trying to lift Mrsha and carry her away!

Images of giant eagles hunting goats and dropping them from huge heights filled Ryoka's mind. She snarled and ran at the bird. The Razorbeak flew away from Mrsha and Ryoka crouched over the Gnoll protectively. She raised her hand.

"Ivolethe? Where the hell are you?"

The Frost Faerie was usually about. But not today. Ryoka concentrated, spoke a word.

"[Flare]!"

She threw an orb of searing bright red light at the bird, which squawked and dove away. The light was harmless, but it made the Razorbeak hesitate. Unfortunately, the bird seemed to sense the magic was just light and dove at Ryoka instead. It clawed at Ryoka as she swore and tried to fend it off while reaching for her belt knife.

"Ryoka! *Duck!*"

Someone shouted. Ryoka ducked. She heard a whirring noise, and a *thunk*. The Razorbeak attacking her suddenly went limp and fell on Ryoka. She shoved it away and staggered back with Mrsha. Ryoka had a dagger in her hands, but there was no need to use it.

The Razorbeak was dead. A kitchen knife stuck out of the bird's chest. Sharp as a razor, it had gone through the bird's body, ending it in moments.

"Are you okay?"

Erin was standing in the doorway, a frying pan and another knife in her hands. Ryoka stared at her as Mrsha clung to her chest, sobbing. Slowly, she brought Mrsha inside and when the Gnoll was being hugged by Lyonette and Drassi, she looked at Erin.

All the fear went one way. All the fury too. Ryoka didn't thank Erin for saving her or Mrsha. She looked at Erin and flicked the mana stone on the

table. Then she nodded to the Razorbeak's corpse lying just outside.

"For someone who doesn't like killing, you're awfully good at it."

Erin's face went white. Ryoka waited.

"Ryoka, Erin, please."

Lyonette had heard it all of course. Ryoka turned her head and Erin punched her stomach. Ryoka swore and hit Erin in the shoulder before dodging back from Erin's next swing.

Erin kicked her. Ryoka threw the magical chessboard at Erin and missed. She punched Erin twice before the other girl tackled her and they rolled around on the ground, hitting each other. The fight ended when Mrsha leapt into the fray, biting indiscriminately and Lyonette hit both girls with a bucket of water and then the bucket.

A bad mood. The Queen of the Antinium felt like that didn't describe her current feeling. A bad mood was just a chemical imbalance, a result of emotion and circumstance. In lesser creatures it might become an issue if not corrected, but the Antinium were perhaps the most biologically advanced creatures in the world. They could suppress mere bodily imperfections.

But only if they wanted to. The Queen did not want to in this moment. She was furious. Beyond furious. She was *betrayed*.

Klbbkch had told her. Her faithful Revalantor had learned from Xrn—he had told her—

The Grand Queen was not attempting to create more Queens.

That news had broken the Queen of the Free Antinium. It had shattered all her ideals, all the faith she'd put in the Antinium on Izril. They were no longer trying to create more Queens? Why? How could they? Did they think six Queens were all they needed? Had they given up hope? Why?

Was it that they wanted to be the sole rulers of the Antinium?

No. The reasons didn't matter. The outcome was the same. The Queen shifted. In her private chambers, she did something she rarely did. She *moved*.

The Soldiers who guarded her shifted as their Queen slowly rose. She had huge, massive legs and she used them to swivel her gargantuan body around and then fall onto her side. Slowly, awkwardly, the Queen pushed herself across the ground, lifting her body with effort. But she did move, and because she was huge, even a grudging step carried her far.

There was a way out of her quarters. It carried her down a tunnel where no other Antinium ever went, even Klbkch. He probably had bad memories of such places, but it was there the Queen dragged herself. Her voice echoed through the dirt hallway, filled with rage and anger she could barely remember feeling. She hadn't felt like this in years.

"Traitors. Cowards. Fools!"

She whispered to herself, dragging her immense body past primitive rooms she had built. They were all airtight, one of the few places in the Hive that were sealed by proper doors. They had to be; mixing the enzymes, chemicals, and other reagents necessary for the Antinium to change and grow required facilities beyond what most [Alchemists] made use of.

She stopped in front of one of the rooms and rested a palp from one of her feelers on the entrance. The Queen of the Free Antinium knew what was within without having to look.

Corpses. Half-rotted bodies of malformed Antinium, mixtures, formed concoctions of enzymes, chemical triggers made from combinations of magic and alchemy, designed to trigger sequences in bodies as they grew. And sacs, embryos. Gelatinous containers like those that Workers and Soldiers emerged from, but far different.

Experiments. Forbidden of course and practically doomed to failure because the Queen of the Free Antinium lacked the resources the other Queens kept to themselves. Without them, she could not create specialized Antinium. But she had tried, oh yes. She had rediscovered the Rite of

Anastasis through her experimentations, saved her beloved Klbkch's life with it. And Ksmvr had been created here.

Still, it was the countless failures that paused the Queen's body as she recalled the years of death that had gone on here. That did not stop her from turning to the carefully arranged collection of bottles and objects on the far wall, however.

"My work. It must be done. We cannot let the Antinium die here. Six queens? We should be legion. We should have names. I thought—they are failures, all of them. We should never have become so *small*."

The Queen reached for a bottle of saltpeter. She hesitated, turned to an extract used in creating new Antinium. She would need eggs. The Queens of the Antinium produced eggs as a matter of course; it was one of the reasons why they grew so large, so they could sustain the populations of their hives. There were Birthers too—Antinium designed for one purpose. But the Queen of the Free Antinium used only her eggs for these experiments. It was...just.

She had no idea where she could begin. How could you create a Queen out of the base materials? What were the formulas her predecessors had used? The Queen of the Free Antinium wished she could remember anything of it, but she had never once been privy to the process. Not before it was too late.

She had not been made for this. Once upon a time she had been young, a new Queen, barely more than a child created to venture to a new world. Over three hundred Queens had been sent, the majority of the living Antinium, to flee. To build and reproduce and prepare for their enemy's return. They had left a rearguard to fight for years, decades if need be. But the sleeping god would one day overrun Rhir, and so the Antinium had left. To win, retreat. To survive, flee.

But never to hide. The Antinium had sent warrior-queens, geniuses who fused and melded Antinium shapes into new forms. They had sent their Centenium, the ageless champions of old.

And they had all died. The Queen of the Free Antinium tasted despair on her mandibles. They had drowned at sea, died battling krakens and

monsters from the depths. The Antinium had underestimated the sea. And what was left was unworthy.

Eight fools who were not qualified, not trained. A handful of uncertain Queens trying to rebuild the majesty they had been born of. And of that number, six remained.

“Six, and it seems only I recall what our purpose is.”

The Queen’s body shuddered. Traitors, all. How could they? If only she could speak with them. But she was an outcast, wasn’t she? What irony. At least it would help her now. She selected the gel that was the beginning of life for Antinium eggs and smeared it gently into a stone basin.

“It was said that we sacrificed a million lives for the first Centenium. I will sacrifice my Hive and my body if I must. But we shall have Queens again. We shall have champions. Klbkchhezeim—you shall not keep faith in vain.”

The Queen sighed. She was too tired. Too old, too weary of keeping her Hive intact. Too alone. That was why she sat in her rooms, eating, managing her Hive, leaving the rest of the world to Klbkch, who had ever been more qualified than her to lead their people.

But now she felt like she was waking up. She could not trust the Grand Queen, or the other Queens. They had lost the way. Perhaps some remembered. Perhaps Xrn was wrong. But until then—the Queen’s feelers shook. But it had started. She reached for another reagent, selecting carefully, hesitating, memorizing her attempts for the inevitable next time.

She began to create.

It really was her fault. Ryoka knew that. But there was truth in what she’d told Erin. She knew that too.

She wasn't good at friends. Perhaps that was why it was easier for Ryoka to apologize to Erin after they'd both cooled down and ask for forgiveness. Sincerely. Because Ryoka was terrified of losing a friend, one of the few she had.

Not that an apology could heal things over so quickly. It was only the start. However, Lyonette had a hand in the next bit of reconciliation. Because both girls were filthy from the slime and fighting, she suggested they take a bath in one of Liscor's public bathhouses.

It was a first for Ryoka to experience that. Normally she paid a lot of money for water to be hauled up to a bathtub or showered with water, again in bucket form.

But Drakes were a bit more civilized than Humans, or smarter. Liscor had a set of very high-quality bathhouses that reminded Ryoka of the Romans. They even had private bathing spots you could rent for a small fee.

It was an excellent service and Ryoka purchased that for the two girls today. The water in the pool they'd rented was hot and wonderful after the cold winter air. Ryoka exhaled slowly as she got into it—completely nude.

Unlike a Japanese *onsen* which she was familiar with, the Drake bathhouses didn't require people to wash themselves before getting in. That sounded awful and disgusting to both Ryoka and Erin until the purification spells had been pointed out to them. Gnolls loved to bathe and they couldn't exactly take off their fur before entering.

"I think its weird how Gnolls and Drakes bathe separately. Isn't that a problem?"

"Dunno."

Erin spoke shortly as she tested the hot water with a toe. She was more embarrassed about being naked than Ryoka, despite the baths being gender-specific. She shrugged as Ryoka heard the sounds of Drakes chattering away outside of their bath. Erin cocked her head, and sniffed the scented waters before continuing.

"Gnolls are touchy-feely and Drakes aren't always like that. It makes sense to give them their own room, and Selys says she went to the

bathhouse with Krshia the other day, so it's not like there's a big rule against it."

"I guess."

The two girls fell silent. Ryoka submerged herself deeper, feeling the heat and enjoying it. The little monster in her brain was gone. Shame and guilt didn't get rid of it, but a splash of healing potion and Mrsha's betrayed glance had banished the specters in Ryoka's head at once. She was left tired, remorseful.

"How's the water?"

Erin asked as if she didn't know. Ryoka hesitated, closed her mouth on the smart-ass response.

"Hot."

The other girl entered the water slowly, yelping a bit at the heat. She submerged herself quicker after getting both legs in. For a while, the two drifted, and said more in looks and silence than they did in words. Ryoka was sure Erin could see the emotions in her eyes. One thing Erin could do was read people when she put her mind to it. Ryoka wondered if that was a chess skill.

"Did you—did you ever go to things like anger management class?"

It wasn't the start of the conversation, but it was the important bit. Ryoka sighed as she and Erin sat together on the underwater ledge.

"Of course. My dad insisted after the second time I got arrested."

"And? Did it...?"

"Nope. Didn't help. I got therapy, pills, the whole nine yards. I hated and resisted all of it. Especially because the therapist was working on my dad's orders, not to help me. And the pills..."

"Didn't work?"

"Oh, they did. They turned me into someone else. I refused to ever take them again."

“Bet your dad didn’t like that. Did he try to make you take them?”

“Yeah. It stopped when I started sneaking them into *his* drinks. Ever seen a bunch of rich assholes—sorry, I mean, businesspeople—go totally insane from drinking a bottle of wine spiked with Xanax? Sight to see.”

“I get it. And I know you’re right about dangers and stuff. It’s just that when you said all that—”

“I was wrong.”

“No, you were right. Rags *is* a problem. I don’t know where she is. That big Hobgoblin looked sort of scary and Toren—”

“Look, I probably wouldn’t have given him a chance. Despite him turning out...the way he did, he still got treated better than he would have if someone like Pisces was ordering him around.”

“I wish I could go back and fix things.”

Erin hugged her knees. Ryoka sighed.

“Hell, maybe you can. Toren’s like a horror story. And you know how those go—”

“Monster comes back. I know. I’ve been asking Wesle, Klbkch, and Relc whenever they come in. No unusual skeleton sightings. If I hear of one...”

“If you hear of one, you tell Halrac or Jelaqua or Pisces. *You* don’t do anything.”

“Right.”

There was a peculiar feeling in the air. It was a sound as much as feeling. It was the sound of people trying to say sorry without saying sorry. Of course, in the end someone gives up and says it out loud. Ryoka did it twice, Erin once.

After a while, someone opened the curtains to their bath. Ryoka and Erin looked up. The convivial atmosphere they’d created blew out. Not instantly—at first they thought it was just a bather who’d gotten the wrong private tub.

“Sorry, we’ve reserved this one.”

Erin smiled and waved at a red-scaled Drake, an older female with a scar down one arm. The Drake returned the smile and closed the curtain behind her.

“I know. You are Erin Solstice and Ryoka Griffin, aren’t you? Please, let me introduce myself. I am Welsca Crimonscale. In service to Wall Lord Ilvriss.”

Ryoka sat up at once at the name. Erin frowned.

“Wall Lord—you mean that jerk I threw a pan at? Is he okay?”

Welsca smiled at Erin and then at Ryoka, looking friendly.

“He is. And you may be happy to know that Wall Lord Ilvriss has decided to forgive any transgressions made against him. You may consider yourselves fortunate for that.”

Erin and Ryoka exchanged a glance. Ryoka folded her arms over her breasts. Drakes didn’t have breasts, at least, nothing that floated. Welsca slid into the water, further amplifying the unpleasantness of the moment. No one had invited her in.

“I believe Lord Ilvriss would consider it a personal favor—as well as an act of trust—if he were to have a chance to speak with you, Miss Griffin. I’m sure you’re aware that there is a need for conversation, and if you feel uncomfortable speaking with him, I would be happy to relay—”

“You’re in our pool. Get out.”

Welsca cut off. Erin and Ryoka were glaring at her. She swished her tail gently in the water and sighed.

“Miss Solstice, Miss Griffin, I don’t think you understand. This is a serious matter. Assaulting a Wall Lord and withholding information—”

Erin splashed her. The dignified Drake lady blinked as water ran down her face. Erin stuck her tongue out.

“Bleh! Get out of our bath! No one’s allowed to mess with private baths, not even a Wall Lord!”

“Ladies, please. I am one of Lord Ilvriss’ most trusted aides. I—”

“Get out.”

Ryoka’s tone could have frozen over their tub. Welsca hesitated. Erin made a fist, cracked her knuckles, yelped, and winced.

The red-scaled Drake could read the mood. She could also probably predict the near future, at least in this situation. But she was stuck. She had her orders. She smiled weakly at the two girls’ hostile faces.

“Perhaps if we all soaked for a moment...?”

The main bathing hall in the women’s section of the bathhouse was slick from steam and bathers walking around. Thus, the walkways were made of rough stone for traction. Nevertheless, children both Drake and Gnoll loved to slide around on the rest of the bathing areas. It wasn’t exactly polite, and they often got in trouble when they slid into someone else’s pool, but it did happen.

It was rarer for adults to do that. Then again, there was a notable incident in which Relc and Klbkch had been banned for that exact practice. Legends were still told about that day, which had required healing potions for at least six people. But on the women’s side things were generally peaceful, chatter being the main focus.

That pleasant ambiance was shattered by a raised voice coming from one of the private bathing areas. There was a shout, splashing of water, and then a *crack*.

Heads turned. The Gnolls and Drake ladies saw a female Drake with red scales slide headfirst across the slick marble floors. She looked battered.

A young woman darker of skin than most inhabitants of Izril and totally naked, came out from behind a curtain. Another young girl followed her, electing to use the curtain as a towel. Ryoka Griffin stomped towards Welsca. The other Drake got up. She tried to back away and slipped on a wet tile. Ryoka kicked her and watched her splash into a pool filled with Gnolls.

She laughed at Welsca as the Drake flailed around in the pool. Ryoka made fists and waited at the pool's edge. She felt a *lot* better. Hitting someone who deserved it was a very pleasant experience in contrast, Ryoka decided. She stared down at Welsca, ignoring the stares around her.

“Hah! What are you going to do now?”

Ryoka sat in Liscor's guardhouse, both hands bound by cord. She stared at the table in front of her and looked around. A Drake [Guardsmen] with a club was eying her, and the room was filled with other criminals. Petty thieves, brawlers, and an angry Gnoll covered in egg yolk who was screaming at another Gnoll. Ryoka sighed.

“Crap.”

It turned out that kicking someone out of your private hot tub wasn't a crime, but kicking them into someone *else's* tub was. Moreover, since Ryoka had been doing the kicking, it was she who was in handcuffs until someone could interview her and get the full story out under truth spell.

She looked around. Liscor's barracks were fairly large. This being the reception area, Ryoka couldn't see much, but the Drakes seemed very keen on military organization. Drakes and Gnolls off-duty did loiter around of course, but there was a sense of purpose that struck Ryoka as very different from the relaxed Human [Guardsmen] who generally ambled about the city.

That was because Drakes trusted their militias to handle monsters and criminals alike. Adventurers were necessary, but the first and last line of defense for any city was their police force, which doubled as their army and in this case, judicial system.

“Miss Ryoka Griffin?”

One of the Drakes on duty came over at last. He had faintly purple scales and some ill-fitting armor. He also had a sheaf of notes that Ryoka hoped weren't all complaints from the other bathers.

“That’s me. Look, I’m sorry about the fight, but that Drake *did* enter our bathing spot—”

“Please. We’ll get to that in a moment.”

Ryoka fell silent. At least he didn’t look openly hostile and wasn’t telling her to *shut up* because she was a filthy Human. Still, she didn’t like the fact that she’d hit an aide of a Lord of the Wall. She didn’t regret doing it broadly speaking, but in situations like this, that fact was a lot more pressing.

“So, this incident between you and Miss Crimonscale...I see there was another Human involved. One Erin Solstice. Yes...we have a few notes from the Watch Captain, Senior Guardsmen Klbkch, Senior Guardsmen Relc, several complaints...she has quite a file.”

That didn’t sound good. Ryoka braced herself, ready to pay a fine if it meant no one got in trouble. She heard a shout.

“Hey, what’s going on here?”

Someone came stomping over to their table. The Drake with purple scales looked up, looking faintly alarmed. Ryoka twisted and saw a Drake with dark green scales and—Ryoka stared—*huge* arms striding forward. He was big for a Drake, big for a Gnoll—he looked like he was all muscle and he had scars on his arms and legs.

He was also carrying a spear, but he tossed it to one corner of the room carelessly. He approached the table, narrowing his eyes for a moment at Ryoka.

“What’s with the Human? I heard there was an incident with her and Erin. Someone punched one of us?”

He looked at the [Guardsman]. Ryoka was sure that talking about a case in front of the guilty party wasn’t exactly good form, and the [Guardsman] seemed reluctant to speak. He nodded at Ryoka.

“I’ve got this. Uh, don’t worry Senior Guardsman Relc.”

The other Drake’s non-existent eyebrows rose. He opened his mouth and then shrugged, looking unconcerned.

“Okay, but hurry it up! I want Erin back in her inn soon—she promised me I’d get roasted eels tonight, and I want them fresh!”

He knew Erin? Wait a second, Relc...Ryoka remembered him vaguely. They’d met, but only as acquaintances. And he’d clearly forgotten her face. Ryoka knew for a fact that the eels in question had already been cooked and were waiting to be eaten at the inn, but she was grateful for him prompting the other [Guardsmen].

The Drake with purple scales cleared his throat as Relc wandered a few feet away and intruded in a conversation between two Gnolls. He looked harried and kept glancing at Relc. Then he sighed and leaned towards Ryoka.

“Miss Griffin, I’m going to make this very simple. Tell us what we need to and this can be over quickly.”

“Okay, I didn’t start it. Welsca did. I can swear on a truth spell—”

“Not that. Lord Ilvriss wants to know only one thing. Where is [Captain] Periss? How did she die?”

He sat back. Ryoka stared at him and felt a cold chill on her back. He was one of Ilvriss’ people too? She remembered the Drake in the inn at breakfast. Another one?

Was Ilvriss watching her? Listening in on her conversations, hoping she’d leak something? She stared at the Drake. He nodded slightly, as if confirming her worst fears.

“Lord Ilvriss is not accustomed to waiting. You may have the immunity of your Guild, but he will seek you out no matter where you go. Speak now, and this need not get worse.”

“Go to hell.”

The fake [Guardsmen] sighed. He flicked through the notes on his clipboard.

“Miss Ryoka, your friend Erin Solstice has a file on her that would attract the attention of any Drake [Leader] in any city. Why Watch Captain Zevara seems content to let her unauthorized inn stand...suspected ties with

the Antinium, disorderly conduct, endangerment and *death* of a Watch member on duty. She may be safe here, but if word of her actions reaches the de facto governing body of Liscor, their army, for instance...a few words in the ears of another Lord or Lady of the Wall might prompt them to take action, and the Assassin's Guild in Izril is quite, quite competent."

Ryoka stared at the Drake.

"Touch Erin and I'll make sure Zel Shivertail learns about it. He kicked your precious Wall Lord's tail once, and he'll do it again. He stays at Erin's inn, or isn't that on file?"

The fake officer of the Watch's eyes flashed. He leaned across the table and seized Ryoka's arm in one unfriendly claw, digging into her skin.

"Listen here, you Human flesh bag. Tell me what I want, or—"

Ryoka kicked him. She'd been waiting for him to get close and gave him her best kick right to his groin. He doubled over and let go. She backed out her chair, kicked him again, and then hit him with both her hands tied up.

"Hey!"

The other [Guardsmen] had seen what was going on. The one called Relc leapt over a table and ran at Ryoka. She whirled, ready to kick him too. She lashed out—and he slid around her kick like water.

"Criminal! Take this! [Relc Headbutt]!"

He slammed his head into Ryoka's. She sat down. And then slid out of her chair. Relc kicked the chair away and dragged her up.

"Assaulting a [Guardsmen]? Here? You're really stupid, Miss Human. Even if you are a friend of Erin's, you're not getting away with that. Hey buddy, you okay?"

The Drake that Ryoka had kicked was getting up in her swirling vision. He shook his head and knocked away Relc's offered hand. He growled at Ryoka, murder in his eyes. He took one step forwards and then Relc let Ryoka go.

One hand shot out, barring the purple Drake's path. The Drake stopped, looking confused. Ryoka felt confused. And ready to sit down. But Relc's eyes were narrowed.

"Wait a second. Who are you? You're not one of the new guys. I know them all and none of them have purple scales."

"Damnit."

The purple Drake took a step back. Relc turned away from Ryoka and she decided to lie down again. The imposter took a desperate swing at Relc. The big Drake leaned back from the blow and then returned it.

"[Relc Punch]!"

He hit the fake guardsmen a lot harder than he'd hit Ryoka. The Drake back-flipped over the table and Ryoka heard a *thud* as he landed.

"Hah! Take that! That proves you're not one of our guys—no one picks a fight with me! Don't you know who I am? I'm Relc! Relc!"

Ryoka managed to sit up and saw Relc posing, one foot on the fallen Drake's chest. He looked inordinately proud of himself, and then frowned as he saw she was up.

"Hey. You. Miss Human."

He'd already forgotten her name. Ryoka forgave him that; at the moment she couldn't remember what the color orange was. Relc helped her up, removing her bindings as she sat on a chair and tried to tell whether the banging was in her mind, or whether her brain was bouncing around.

"Who was that guy? He has a set of our armor and everything."

"Wall Lord...Ilvriss. His person. Like the bathhouse."

"Oh. *Oh*."

Relc slapped his forehead and nodded at the other [Guardsmen] who'd gathered around. They grunted and immediately picked up the fallen Drake and shoved him into a corner. That they didn't toss him out of the barracks or throw him in a cell was probably due to his master's fame.

While Ryoka put her head down, she heard Relc speaking with the others. Then his loud voice called out as an angry female Drake demanded to know why one of her people was unconscious on the floor.

“Hey, Captain Z! Turns out this Human and Erin didn’t start anything. It’s that Wall Lord guy’s cronies stirring up trouble again. I’m going to let the Human go, okay? And I’m taking my lunch break! Be back in an hour!”

Relc helped Ryoka up and practically pushed her out the door. Ryoka heard a frustrated roar coming from behind her.

“Damn it, Relc! *Get back here!*”

Of course, if you focused too much on Ryoka, you neglected other interesting things. A bit of garlic fell from the sky and landed on Brunkr’s fur as he showed Lyonette how to hold her sword. He brushed it off absent-mindedly.

“Good. Hold it here, see? Yes. And swing. Quickly—a cut should be fast. Yes, like so.”

He was teaching her. And Lyonette was learning. They practiced outside in the cleared snow as Mrsha sat and watched. Inside, Apista was tethered to a table with a leash Erin had gotten while Ishkr cleaned up.

It was an all-Gnoll parade, in short, except for Lyonette. And perhaps that would have been awkward or fatal for her a week or two ago. But things had changed.

Lyonette had changed a lot. All sins were forgiven, and a debt had been written for her actions. More than that, and perhaps more importantly, Brunkr had changed. He was no longer the self-confident Gnoll [Warrior], but a recovering one, grateful for his still-healing arm and quietly guilty. He and Ryoka would have understood each other, in that.

Still, only Erin would have thought it was a good idea to have him near Mrsha, the person who'd bit him and infected his hand, and Lyonette, the girl he'd tried to kill. But as Ryoka had noticed, Erin did have an eye for these things now and then. When Brunkr had first arrived, he and Mrsha had sniffed each other for a bit, solemnly, but said nothing. Lyonette and Brunkr on the other hand were different.

She was guilty as he was, in a different way. She had apologized to him first, and then him to her. It had ticked both to realize that Lyonette hadn't remembered Brunkr specifically trying to kill her, and a friendship had started once Brunkr realized that Lyonette was the one responsible for his honey salve.

That was the boring bit. The special bit for any watching fae nibbling at garlic came at a moment when Brunkr mentioned his aspirations.

“A [Knight]?”

Lyonette put down her sword and massaged her aching arms. She wanted the [Warrior] class too, and felt she might get it by the end of the day. Brunkr nodded, looking embarrassed.

“It is a very Human class. There are some Drakes with similar classes, but no Gnoll has the class, yes? Similar classes, but I found a book when I was young. My tribe had bought it from a [Trader] and my aunt let me read it...there were pictures of Human [Knights] in shining armor. I admired them and wished to be like them. So I trained with sword and shield. However, I am only a [Warrior].”

“Well, that's because you need a [Lord] to make you one, or some other nobility.”

“Hrr. Yes, that is what I have been told. I came north to help my aunt and also to see whether that would be possible. I think...it may not be. Entering in service to a Human [Lord] requires much trust and perhaps standing I do not have. It matters not. I am still useful to my Tribe and my efforts have made me a strong warrior nevertheless.”

Brunkr shrugged his broad shoulders, hiding his disappointment behind casual words. Lyonette nodded, hesitating. Her eyes lingered on the Gnoll's

back as he stood up to exchange a few words with Ishkr. They were around the same age, although Brunkr was older. He wasn't much older than Lyonette, really.

Yes, a faerie could see what would happen next. Perhaps a Human could too. Destiny wove together and Lyonette raised her hand. She whispered quietly.

"I, Lyonette du Marquin do solemnly..."

Mrsha had been playing in the snow, quite close to the inn, but poking her head under the snow and rolling around in delight. Suddenly, she raised it and stared at Lyonette, ears flicking with each word Lyonette spoke.

The two Gnolls had finished speaking at the door to the inn. Ishkr was going back into the inn, collecting dishes to be washed and Brunkr was sniffing at the entrance to the inn, his stomach audibly rumbling. But as Lyonette whispered both froze up.

Ishkr slipped and dropped his entire tray of empty dishes. They *crashed* to the ground inside the inn, scaring Erin half to death as she cooked up some food for dinner.

Brunkr's eyes opened wide. He half-turned, and then pretended to scratch at one ear. Lyonette finished speaking. Her voice had been inaudible to anyone standing next to her, carried away just as swiftly by the wind. Now she stared at Brunkr's back and cleared her throat. Trying to sound casual, she raised her voice.

"Brunkr, can you show me how to parry again? I think I'm doing it wrong."

"Ah?"

He started, and then turned. His smile was about as fake as Lyonette's. Mrsha was still staring.

"Of course. I will show you. Lyonette."

He trudged across the snow to Lyonette as Erin rushed out of her kitchen, demanding to know if there was another one of Ilvriss' spies. Ishkr

reassured her nothing was wrong, Brunkr showed Lyonette how to hold her blade correctly, and Mrsha kept staring.

Above them a Frost Faerie cackled with glee and waited for Relc to drag Ryoka up the slope and into the inn. Destiny. Coincidence. Or perhaps just an act of kindness from a girl who happened to be a [Princess]. Who knew?

One thing was sure, though. Despite having lived in Liscor for over a month now, Lyonette still hadn't learned how sensitive Gnoll ears could be.

“And then I hit him! Pow! Hey Hawk, I didn't know you knew Ryoka too! What, do all Runners know each other?”

“We've met before. I'm surprised you don't remember Miss Ryoka, Relc. She once ran through the High Passes on a delivery.”

“Get out, really? I thought I remembered her, but you know Humans. They all look alike, am I right? Ah. Ahem.”

Relc was laughing in the common room. Somehow he'd dragged Ryoka up from the city—Erin was a bit fuzzy on the details, but apparently there had been a quick fight. He'd encountered Hawk the Rabbit-tribe Beastkin on the way and the Courier had stopped by for a drink with Ryoka.

Olesm was due later that evening, and Erin was busy. Ishkr was cleaning up plate fragments—he said he'd tripped, which was uncharacteristically clumsy of the Gnoll, and Lyonette and Brunkr were training outside with Mrsha.

On the whole of things, Erin could claim to be happy. Sure, the morning's incident with Ryoka had been bad, but they'd made up and she was glad to see Brunkr was really getting along with Lyonette now. And best of all, she'd made another amazing invention!

It was the slime. Erin peered at it as she stared at the tiny hand-sized thing in the center of a saucepan. This slime was bright blue, with shades of yellow running through it. It was a healing potion slime.

“Drop it into a healing potion, wait, and hey presto! I *knew* it was possible!”

Erin crowed to herself softly as she spooned a bit of the slime up. She’d tested it on a cut and it had healed perfectly. Now she added a bit of water to the slime and saw it absorbed the liquid and grow, replacing the bit she’d taken with water.

“Hmm. Looks like you get diluted if I add just water. But if I feed you all the ingredients of your potion, you’ll probably just get bigger *and* more potion-y, right?”

She smiled at the slime. It didn’t respond. Erin moved the spoon towards it again. In line with Ryoka’s wishes, she’d kept the slime very small just in case it attacked someone. Her spoon penetrated the slime’s side and it suddenly scooted away from the spoon.

“Huh? Hey! Get back here, I need part of you!”

Erin chased the slime around the saucepan with her spoon. She eventually cornered the slime against one side with another spoon and prepared to take part of it. But Erin hesitated when she noticed something. Or rather, something the slime was doing.

It was shaking. The blob of colored liquid pressed itself against the wall of the saucepan. When Erin moved her spoon towards it, it trembled harder. When she took it away, the slime shook less.

But it did shake. It was like jelly. Only, jelly couldn’t squeeze itself so finely against the metal walls of its cage and quiver. Jelly couldn’t be afraid.

“Oh no. Hey little guy. I’m not going to take *all* of you. I want to take—just a bit, see? You’ll get it back. I’ll feed you!”

Erin reached out with one hand, putting the spoon down. The slime reacted violently to her fingers, flowing away and around them. It quivered as Erin reached out towards it. The healing slime shook like a leaf.

“What? I’m not scary. It’s just my hand, see?”

The girl reached out and the slime froze. It was such a—a universal reaction that Erin froze too. And she understood something, in that moment as the slime slowly backed away from her fingertips.

“Slimes *can* think. Oh. Oh no.”

There was no other way to see it. Erin knew fear. She could see it in the blob that ran from her touch. She could see it. The slime had no face to show her, no body parts, no voice. But it could not be anything but afraid.

And then Erin realized that it was the same slime, the same core that she’d taken out of the water slime this morning. She wondered if it remembered. And then she looked at the slime as it tried to hide from her and knew it did.

“Oh no no no...but Typhenous said they don’t feel pain!”

He said that. Erin recalled him saying that. But—but if a slime couldn’t feel pain, couldn’t it still feel loss? What would it be like if someone scooped out part of your body, even if it didn’t hurt? Erin reached out and the slime would have screamed if it had a voice. She felt sure of that.

“Oh.”

And in the end, Ryoka was right. It was Toren all over again. Only this time, Erin could see it. She looked at the slime and wondered what it would be like, to live all your life in a cage and have someone feed you and consume you for...for however long you lived.

“I can’t do that. Can I?”

Erin whispered as her inn began to fill up. The Gold-rank adventurers and her regular guests were returning. She heard Olesm’s eager voice, asking about her.

It took Erin only a moment to decide. She grabbed the saucepan, splashed water in it, tossed a handful of garlic in, some oil—the slime bulged, growing distorted, losing the properties of its healing potion. It was now filling the saucepan.

Erin went over to the window and unlatched it. A cold wind blew in, making her shiver. The slime didn't shiver. It only shook when Erin reached for it.

“Erin?”

That was Octavia's voice. She was coming closer, and now Erin could hear Typhenous.

“Wonderful news, Miss Solstice! I have the lodestones I ordered. Have you finished your experiments with the slime from this morning?”

There was no time. Erin hesitated, and then poured it out of the window. The slime dropped into the snow and she saw it vanish into the deep drift outside her window.

“Erin?”

Typhenous and Octavia walked into the kitchen, looking excited. Octavia glanced around.

“Where's that slime? Did the healing potion work like you thought?”

Erin gave Octavia a blank look. Then her eyes widened.

“Oh yeah! The slime! It didn't work guys. Sorry.”

“No. Really?”

The [Mage] and [Alchemist] looked crestfallen. Erin nodded slowly.

“Yeah, it was sucky. The slime grew from the healing potion, you know? But when I tried using a bit of it...no go.”

“Perhaps it's the magical effect that dissipates. It cannot be part of a living creature...of course. I should have predicted that.”

Typhenous groaned, shaking his head. Octavia nodded and looked around.

“Maybe we can try again. Hey Erin, where's the slime?”

“The slime? It's right here of c—”

Erin went over to a pot and opened the lid. The [Mage] and [Alchemist] saw her freeze and look up slowly. She gave them a weak smile that fooled neither of them, and in doing so, fooled both of them.

“Oops. Where’d it go?”

Typhenous and Octavia stared askance at Erin. She put on her best bemused look and shrugged her shoulders. And she made sure that everyone heard the story later that night. Healing slimes were impossible to make, as it turned out. Of course.

Only an idiot would try to make one.

Nearly there. Nearly time. A bit of sausage fell into Typhenous’ beard. He didn’t notice. He was speaking to the other adventurers sitting around him, looking frustrated.

“At least I have my delivery of lodestones. That will allow us to produce something of worth tonight.”

“You can make the door? Really?”

Erin looked excited. Typhenous smiled and nodded.

“It will be a simple matter to attune the stones. I’ve already done one.”

He flicked his fingers at a red stone carved with a glowing symbol. Its twin sat next to it.

“The real challenge will be delivering each stone to its destination and affixing it in a proper place. Merely getting the stone to its intended destination will take some time...I suspect you may have to hire a City Runner to send it, although finding a suitable location will also be important. I would suggest hiring Miss Ryoka in that regard.”

“Ryoka? Sure!”

Erin glanced over at Ryoka. The Runner girl had recovered enough and was now drinking with Relc and Hawk. She frowned.

“But where should the stones go, in that case? You said it’s hard to have a lot of destinations—”

“Exponentially difficult. Too much interference. However, that should not be a great issue if you limit your door to three or four set anchors.”

“Okay, assuming we leave an emergency stone with you guys...and I want Celum, obviously...where should the other ones go?”

The old [Mage] coughed delicately.

“Might I suggest a door to Invril first? I should quite like to return there at my leisure, and I am sure many would pay well for such a service.”

Octavia nodded, looking eager.

“Not to mention how lucrative it would be for me—I mean, for everyone to sell their goods in Invril. They haven’t seen my matches yet, and I don’t want to miss out on sales before everyone copies my recipe!”

“Hah! Invril?”

Someone had heard them. The adventurers looked over and saw Relc waving a half-full mug at them. He scowled at the Humans. Revi scowled at him.

“Something wrong with Invril? It’s one of the biggest cities on the continent, you know!”

“Not as big as a Walled City! Why’s Erin got to put her fancy magic door to one of your cities first, huh? She’s already got Celum—give our cities a chance!”

“Yeah!”

Olesm, sitting at a table and playing chess with Pawn, raised his voice. He called out to Erin, waving a sheaf of papers.

“I know several [Tacticians] in Pallass—why not put your door in the Walled City? Drakes would love a chance to bypass the Blood Fields, the

Walled Cities are far better than any Human city—not that I mean to offend anyone.”

“Offense taken!”

Revi sat up at her table and scowled at Olesm.

“Invrisil’s obviously the better choice. You Drakes might think your home is all that, but—”

“Hah! Drakes rule, Humans...Humans drool!”

Relc was clearly drunk. However, his comment elicited a roar of approval from every Drake in the room. Olesm gave a thumbs-up to Relc, and the Drake returned the gesture. It was very Human and very, very odd since Drake claws were a lot scarier than Human thumbs.

Before Erin knew it, an argument had erupted in her inn over which city was better. Helplessly, she turned to ask for Ryoka’s opinion and found herself face-to-face with Zel Shivertail.

“I couldn’t help hearing what the argument was about, Miss Erin.”

The [General] leaned over her table, speaking quietly as Relc threw a mug and brained Typhenous. The mage threw a mug back and soon a fight had broken out—in the form of arm wrestling. Somehow it was now about which species was stronger and Ulrien was already squaring up against Relc, to the cheers of their audience.

“Oh? You want me to put my door in Pallass, right Zel?”

Erin felt awkward speaking with Zel, mainly because she thought he still disapproved of her. But Zel just nodded. He didn’t smile, rather, he frowned and looked a bit concerned.

“I wouldn’t ask normally—I can live without going home and prefer it that way. But I’ve been speaking with a friend—a fellow [General], actually, and I’ve fallen out of touch these last few days. I’d love a chance for some news, and there’s a bit of a situation among the Drakes...could I sway your opinion a bit?”

The door to Celum burst open. Erin saw Garia rush into the room, waving her arms, as Relc beat Ulrien to a roar of amazement from the crowd.

“Hah! Take...take that! I win!”

The Drake shakily stood back and crowed before Ulrien shook his hand, taking the wind out of Relc’s victory. She caught a bit of what Garia was telling Ryoka excitedly.

“I’m a [Martial Artist]! Can you *believe* it? I got this Skill—[Basic Footwork].”

Relc had spotted Garia. He eyed the large girl and shouted at her.

“Ooh! Nice muscles! Hey, Human girl! Want to arm wrestle? I bet you can beat Miss Ryoka here, and probably Hawk, too!”

It was all chaos. It always was with Relc. But seeing him here made Erin smile. She looked at Zel and made a spur-of-the-moment decision. It wasn’t hard, and it didn’t matter much, right? There were lodestones to go around.

Ivolethe watched as destiny changed.

“Sure! Why not? I think Ryoka doesn’t want to go down there, but Hawk’s a Courier, right? Maybe I can get a discount if I promise to feed him or something!”

Zel coughed delicately.

“A discount for a Courier is still quite a lot of money. I’m prepared to pay whatever price he asks if he’ll do the delivery?”

“What? You *will*? In that case, I’ll totally do it! Hey Hawk! Stop arm-wrestling and come over here!”

The Rabbit-man walked over, massaging an arm.

“Those Human girls are *strong*. This is why [Farmers] make such great [Warriors]...what can I do for you, Erin? And—*General Shivertail*?”

He hadn't spotted Zel up until now. But when introductions were over, Hawk nodded amiably.

"I can do that. Why not? General Shivertail's a hero in Liscor, and if I don't have to run all the way back...yes, I'm quite willing to do that. I can set out tonight and have the delivery done by the end of tomorrow."

"Really? Tonight?"

"Hey, a job's a job, and if it means opening up a door to Pallass that everyone can use from now on...you do know how important this could be, right? You could earn a fortune. Plus, do you know how many hot Drake ladies there are in the Walled Cites? I uh—forget you heard that last bit."

The Horns of Hammerad were not part of the arm-wrestling competition. They sat in a corner of the inn, arguing over some pieces of paper. Ceria was snapping at Pisces.

"I know you wanted a Gold-rank contract on some lucrative monster, Pisces. It's not happening! We haven't gotten certified yet—the decision will take a while, and we need practice."

"So we lower ourselves to the most common bidder in the meantime? That hardly seems like a productive use of *my* talents."

"Shut it. I think we should hunt the wolves. It's good training and we'll earn—"

"Pittance?"

"...Yeah. But it'll be a contract, and we need to practice fighting *something*. I'm not suggesting we try a Rock Crab first thing, or go into the dungeon. Are you?"

"I made no such intimations. However, I simply think that *wolves* are below our..."

Yvlon Byres sat at the table next to Ksmvr and watched her teammates argue. She was depressed, a mood which had nothing to do with the day's events and all to do with her situation in life.

She was—had been—a [Warrior]. A Level 22 [Warrior]; very respectable and a worthy Silver-rank adventurer in her own right. Her team, the Silver Spears, had been relatively well known in the local area and respected as a competent force. But her fortunes had changed. Yvlon had lost everything, gained everything, and she was now...different.

She's lost her friends, her team, and part of her body. She's gained a new team, and magical items that would make her a Gold-rank adventurer. And something else. A new class.

"Yvlon? What do you think?"

The woman started. She looked at the others and smiled guiltily.

"How about Esthelm?"

"Esthelm?"

They stared at her. Yvlon shrugged.

"It's close by, although we might need horses for quicker travel. But I doubt they've got too many adventurers and they're sure to need help."

"A few contracts around that city? Potentially lucrative. I concur with your thinking, in broad terms, Miss Byres."

Pisces rubbed at his chin, looking intrigued and Ceria pounced on the idea. Ksmvr sat, nodding occasionally and Yvlon sank back into her seat.

Everyone was getting stronger. Ceria was about to learn her new spell, Pisces was...better, and Ksmvr claimed that he thought his fourth arm was growing again. It was all going well. Except...

Yvlon closed her eyes. She had leveled up. Gained a new class. Only it wasn't the one she'd always dreamed of. Instead—

She was Yvlon Byres. A Level 26 [Wounded Warrior].

No one knew. Yvlon hadn't had the courage to tell anyone, yet. How could she? It hurt too much. She was never going to be a [Knight]. She had no idea what she would become. Her brother—she'd never be his equal now. And she was never going home. Never.

The Rabbit-man named Hawk left the inn an hour after the Horns of Hammerad finished deciding to take a few contracts in Esthelm for the time being. Yvlon had seen him, blurring through the snow at lightning speed. She envied his abilities.

Now she and the others were eating some fried eel, and trying to explain to Ksmvr what an eel was. They were laughing, and Yvlon felt that she had to tell them about her class. Now. Perhaps they could help? Even if not, they deserved to know. She opened her mouth, and someone burst through the door. A Human adventurer panted and shouted for everyone's attention.

"A Named Adventurer just entered the city! You won't believe who it is!"

Everyone turned. Moore dropped the massive mug he was using and Jelaqua cursed out loud. Halrac sat up, looking at his teammates with grim resignation.

"Who?"

"Regrika Blackpaw, the hero of the Gnoll tribes! She's formed a two-person team with a Gold-rank adventurer and she's here! *In Liscor!*"

The adventurer shouted the name and every Gnoll in the inn started howling. Mrsha sat up, looking confused, but Ishkr, Brunkr, and the other Gnolls in the inn immediately surged for the door, running towards the city. Caught up by the moment, everyone else did too.

Regrika Blackpaw was a giant of a Gnoll, her fur black as coal, her body armored in splendid golden plate mail. She was a [Champion], a hero who'd sprung out of the earth a few years back and slain incredible

monsters single-handedly. She was accompanied by a slight young Drake, a [Mage] who radiated magical power and who had dark purple scales. Both female adventurers were being greeted with fanfare by all the Gnolls in the city despite the late hour.

This is how it ends. Ivolethe narrowed her eyes at Regrika and swooped down lower. Not to interfere, but watch. Regrika was speaking to Krshia Silverfang, and she'd just caught sight of the Gold-rank adventurers who'd come through the gates. She was striding towards them, paw raised in greeting, when the last thread snapped into place.

Someone burst through the crowd, shouting. People were knocked aside and Hawk nearly ran over the Named Adventurer. People screamed and backed away, because the Rabbit [Courier] had a body in his arms.

A limp Drake with blood on his armor and the insignia of a Drake emblem on his shoulder guard bled crimson onto the frozen paving stones. He bled, but only a few drops. He had died a while back. Hawk shouted as people stepped back, calling up at the [Guardsmen] on the wall.

“Sound the alarm! This is a request from a Courier! Get me the Council and Watch Captain Zevara!”

The members of the Watch did not hesitate. A horn began to blow from the wall, a piercing wail that woke up the city. Hawk turned—he was panting and his fur was damp with sweat. Ivolethe had seen him run south, and then run back. She could grudgingly admit that he had run fast on the way back.

“Hawk!”

Zel Shivertail pushed his way through the crowd, staring at the insignia on the fallen Drake. Hawk turned to him, and the [General] stared down at the dead soldier.

“Where did you find him?”

“Not thirty miles down the road south of here. He was barely alive; my healing potions bought him only a few moments.”

Zel bowed his head over the Drake.

“What did he say?”

“The Goblin Lord. He crushed both armies sent against him. Crushed them—Garusa Weatherfur is *dead*, and Thrissiam Blackwing ordered both armies to buy time for word to be sent to the other cities! There’s something wrong with the Goblin Lord. He’s a powerful [Necromancer] as well as a leader!”

Hawk’s voice provoked gasps and screams in the crowd. Zel swore.

“To the Council. They need to hear of it at once! Go! I’ll follow!”

Hawk nodded. The Rabbit Beastkin ran through the streets, legs blurring, out of sight in a moment. Zel charged down the street after Hawk.

[Guardsmen] followed him, some shouting for people to keep calm and wait for word, others running to find Wall Lord Ilvriss and everyone of note. A Gnoll stopped and bowed before Regrika.

“Lady Blackpaw, we would deeply appreciate your—”

“Of course. Lead on. This is no time for dawdling, no?”

The Gnoll Named Adventurer strode after the [Guardman]. After a moment’s deliberation, Ulrien and Jelaqua both followed, and they were quickly escorted in her wake. The shocked voices of the people echoed above and Ivolethe sighed.

Here it ended. She flew down and alighted on Ryoka’s shoulder. The young woman was holding Mrsha as Erin stood next to her. Everyone was afraid. They reeked of it. They could only see one future. Ivolethe could see many. They were right to be afraid, but they didn’t know all of it.

Nor could she tell them. Ryoka glanced at Ivolethe.

“Do you know anything about this, Ivolethe?”

“If I did, I would not tell ye.”

Ivolethe looked calmly at Ryoka, and saw the girl's eyes roll impatiently.

"If we die—"

"Ye die. I cannot interfere."

Ivolethe sighed. She felt old. Old and tired. In that moment, the wind blew. She felt the world change and realized one thing. Faeries could see the future. They could predict it. But they couldn't see everything.

Time moved. She felt the call, heard the echo in her very soul. She felt the winter shiver, and then—

Ryoka saw Ivolethe sigh. The Frost Faerie looked worn down, tired. And then something happened. Her form, her crystalized icy form slowly blurred. Just for a second, Ryoka thought she smelled damp earth, saw greenery and felt sunlight. For a moment. Then Ivolethe was back to normal.

Almost. Something ran down Ivolethe's face. It gathered, running down her suddenly slick skin, beading, reaching her leg. It fell, a piece of crystal, a frozen bit of ice, onto the ground and shattered. Ivolethe looked around.

Ryoka stared. The Frost Faerie glanced at Ryoka, irritated.

"What? What?"

"Ivolethe. You're...melting."

Ivolethe froze. She looked at herself, and touched at her wet skin. She blinked at Ryoka, surprised, upset, and then—resigned.

“Huh. So I am.”

“What does it—does that mean—”

The Frost Faerie shrugged. She looked at Ryoka, and then at Erin, and finally Mrsha, smiling slightly.

“Winter is ending. And so I suppose we run out of time. Let us make the most of it, Ryoka Griffin.”

With that, she flew up, spiraling through the streets of Liscor as word spread of the Goblin Lord’s army and fear once again rode on the breeze. Fear of the future.

One last thing. The news that struck Liscor and then the rest of the Drake cities like a bomb was almost instantaneous, thanks to the [Message] spells sent out by Zel Shivertail and Ilvriss. However, the Human cities would only hear the news in the morning, mainly thanks to every [Mage] in the Mage’s Guild being monopolized by Drakes.

Only a few individuals got word of what had happened at the same times as the Drakes. People who paid for private information, and paid quite well. Which was why Typhenous’ [Message] spell was immediately relayed to Lord Tyrion Veltras and to Lady Magnolia Reinhart’s presence within moments of casting it.

Magnolia Reinhart sat in a moving carriage and opened the [Message] scroll she'd just been handed by Ressa. The artifact recorded any [Messages] her people deemed important enough to send her directly. And this one was important, oh, yes. Important and very unwelcome indeed.

She stared down at the [Message] as Ressa read it over her shoulder. Her [Maid] uttered several words that made the driver of the carriage swerve erratically, but Magnolia said nothing. What was there to say? She looked out the window at the dark landscape, at the snow, at the night creeping in and said nothing at all.

Instead, she sighed. And fate, like the fading winter, like the wind and indeed, the Goblin Lord himself, took no notice at all.

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“I’m going to quit.”

Niers Astoragon spoke to himself as he stood on his dressing table, inspecting himself in a foot-high mirror. He adjusted the cuffs of the fancy, somber black-and-silver doublet he’d been supplied and wondered if he could strangle himself on the lace.

“Lace. Who uses *lace*? The fashions of Terandria are not Balerosian fashions. Following those idiotic trendsetters is pointless, but why listen to me? Let’s all decide to hang ourselves with string. Lace on the frocks, collars, arms...*leggings* for some reason! In the time it takes to dress up like this I could be playing two games of chess. *Three*.”

He glanced over to a small, wooden board sitting on the table a few feet away from him. It too occupied the dressing room table, which also held Niers’ bed, most of his possessions, and his entire wardrobe. The rest of Niers’ room was given over to a large amount of papers, most stacked with some degree of neatness, but giving the entire place a distinct impression that a tiny person had decided to camp out in the middle of a filing room.

It was, Niers thought to himself, entirely appropriate. Not that the clutter mattered outside of the table; for a Fraerling, the dressing table itself was a gigantic bedroom, complete with treacherous drops several times his height he could throw himself off if he got bored of life.

“Not that I’d die from the fall, even if I landed on my neck. And then I’d have to show up and teach those little leeches wearing a neck brace. Hah! And this week of all weeks? It doesn’t bear thinking about.”

He glanced again at the magical chessboard and shook his head. The pieces hadn’t moved. Thus, there was no real reason for him to delay. Niers sighed.

“How many have I taught? A hundred? A thousand? And how many survive to become great [Strategists] and [Generals]? I don’t need to keep doing this. I could keep playing. I could—could find out—”

He trailed off for a second and looked for a third time at the chess board. Then he looked towards the glass windows in his room, saw the sun rising, and cursed.

“Late!”

He finished tying the lace together like a noose and hurried towards the door. Not the main door to the room though; oh no. The door handle was far too high up for Niers to bother climbing and ruin his wonderf—his perfectly serviceable—his mockery of fashion that was a doublet. No, instead, he took a small ramp upwards towards a door set near the ceiling. Niers opened it, and began to march down the small stone tunnels illuminated by tiny mage lights.

He was using the Fraer-ways. And in doing so, he passed through stone crossroads, walkways along the outside of the palace that had been converted into the academy he lived in. These walkways were naturally enclosed on all sides to protect Fraerlings from birds, rodents, and other dangers, but such was the wealth of Niers’ company, the Forgotten Wing, that the [Architects] had installed glass windows to allow Fraerlings an unparalleled view of the city the academy was based in.

Elvallian, one of the foremost trading hubs in Baleros. Once an obscure city marooned in the jungle, now, the headquarters of the Forgotten Wing Company, home to one of the Four Great Companies of Baleros when they were not on campaign. Also, and just as prominently, the place where aspiring [Strategists] might receive the chance to learn from the legendary Titan himself, the [Strategist] claimed by many to be the highest-level in the world, Niers Astoragon.

At the moment, said Titan, [Grandmaster Strategist], feared foe to his enemies and so on and so forth was cursing. He’d just stepped in rat droppings and it had gotten all over his dress boots, which of course, had lace.

“So that’s why you’re late. Because of rat poo.”

Breakfast. Niers had it every day in an open part of the castle. Not open to the elements; no one wanted to sit in the hot, humid air, rather open in the sense of huge sheets of glass providing the illusion of openness while cooling spells made the room pleasant to sit in.

Niers sat on a table with white cloth, eating from a tiny bowl and scowling at his companion sitting across from him. He was having a civilized breakfast of bananas, a filling porridge, and fruits, all seasoned with some fresh cinnamon.

His partner was having muffins. Not muffins with a side of eggs, or muffins and a glass of milk, or muffins with butter. Just muffins. There were three of them. As Niers watched, the eater of muffins picked one up in her furry paws and stared at it.

“Because of poo.”

“Would you stop calling it that? I stepped in rat *droppings* and needed to change my boots.”

“Why?”

“You know why. We’re supposed to be putting on a show!”

“Hm. So that’s why you have all the string.”

“Lace.”

Niers glared. The person sitting across from him blinked at him. She had odd eyes. Three-Color Stalker was her title. She was a Squirrel Tribe Beastkin. Also, she was the leader of the Forgotten Wing Company, Niers’ boss, oldest friend, and right now, ponderer of muffins.

“I didn’t choose to dress up like this. Apparently, this is the current fashion from Terandria and all of Baleros considers this the height of fashion.”

“Drab clothing and lots of lace.”

The tiny Fraerling gritted his teeth as the Squirrel-woman held her muffin up to the light, studying it.

“The point, as I understand it, is to emphasize muted colors. *Note* the silver lining?”

“Why have lace if it’s not colored?”

“That would be asking too much of fashion, I suppose.”

The Squirrel Beastkin glanced at Niers and smiled for a second. He wasn’t sure if that was because she felt like it, or because she’d gotten the joke. Her name was Foliana and he’d known her for decades, but she was still unpredictable to him. Both of Foliana’s eyes sparkled in the light as they met his.

Three colors made up her eyes. Bright red-pink, deep and dreamy yellow and clear green. They created an orb of three equal parts in the center of her eye. The brown sclera that surrounded the eyes was practically black compared to the brilliance of her pupils.

Her eyes were a wonder. The rest of the Squirrel Beastkin was practically unnoticeable. She faded into her chair, and when sitting seemed to grow transparent and inconspicuous. Niers cleared his throat.

“I note you aren’t wearing any lace.”

“Don’t want to. Lace is hard to sneak around in.”

“You’re not being called on to stab a [Commander] to death in a rainforest. You’re greeting dignitaries, prospective clients, allies. Guests.”

“Mm.”

“That means no stabbing.”

“I know.”

Silence. Niers chewed down his breakfast, hurrying because if he didn’t, he’d be late for class. He made sure not to get a spot on his clothing. Foliana slowly nibbled at her muffin, getting about half of it into her mouth and the rest on the tablecloth.

“I’m thinking about quitting.”

She stopped nibbling and looked at Niers. Not a trace of emotion crossed Foliaana's face.

"Okay."

Niers stared at her. She stared at him.

"This is where you remind me of the good old days."

"Mm. Right. What good old days?"

The Fraerling thought. Then he cursed.

"I'm feeling old, Foliaana. You have grey in your fur—"

"I'm distinguished. You're old and wrinkly. I'm not."

"You have *fur*. That hides your wrinkles."

"Mm. I'd like blueberries."

Niers stared at Foliaana. She stared back. Sometimes they did this for minutes over breakfast. She looked at her muffins first.

"Blueberries are called that because they look blue. What do you call orange berries?"

"...Oranges? Tiwali Magma Bloomers?"

"Mm. Nope. If you want to go, we'll probably be attacked. Mm. Not good. Should probably rethink."

"Our company is fine. So long as you don't engage directly with one of the other three Great Companies—I have my reasons."

"Going to find your mystery chess partner?"

Niers grimaced. Half of Baleros knew by now that he was playing an opponent. Most knew exactly how many games he'd won and lost. (Two wins this week, three losses. Four draws.)

"Don't talk me out of it. I'm done with this pomp and teaching those idiots."

"You have a class in five minutes."

“Really? *Damn*. Big feet squash it all!”

Niers leapt up. He pointed at Foliana as he ran for the Fraer-ways.

“This isn’t over!”

She waved at him with one furred paw as he left. The tiny door slammed shut behind him. Foliana nibbled at a muffin, and then glanced towards the main door to the dining room.

It opened suddenly. Foliana disappeared. One of her subordinates, Peclir Im, edged into the room. He was a [Chamberlain], since [Stewards] were rare and required royalty to appoint them. But he was experienced, high-level, and knew Foliana and Niers well enough to look closely at the table. He coughed.

“Miss Foliana, if you’re here, I would like to know rather than die of a heart attack like my predecessor.”

Grudgingly, she appeared, still sitting at her table. Peclir nodded and approached her.

“Lord Astoragon?”

“He’s teaching class.”

“Ah. I could have summoned a helper to carry him had I been aware.”

“No. He likes running. He feels old if he’s carried. And there’s rat poo in the Fraer-ways.”

“I do apologize. I shall have someone clean the area immediately and put down poison.”

“Mm.”

Foliana nibbled as Peclir cleared Niers’ tiny dishes and half-eaten breakfast from the table. She stared at him without blinking. Peclir for his part—the man was Human, not that it mattered—was used to the scrutiny and kept working undeterred. Cleaning was a job for a lesser class like [Maid] or [Manservant], but Foliana had a habit of disappearing around anyone she didn’t trust, which was nearly everyone. More than one servant had tried to clean a chair with her on it.

People still talked about the previous [Majordomo].

“When are the fancy people arriving?”

Peclir paused and glanced towards the rising sun.

“In an hour, I believe.”

“I have to greet them. They’ll watch Niers teach the first day.”

“Yes, Miss Foliana. And there will be the banquet in two days as all of the guests will have arrived then. Lord Astoragon has requested me to tell you that attendance is mandatory.”

“Mm.”

Silence. That was natural. Three-Color Stalker was a legend few had ever seen. She was a [Rogue] of the highest order, but her talents made most [Assassins] green with envy, especially when she stabbed them from behind.

“Peclir?”

“Yes, Miss Foliana?”

“You’ve been working for four years now. Almost exact.”

“My anniversary is this month. I’m pleased you recall.”

“Mm. Yes, good. Loyalty is good.”

“Yes, Miss Foliana. Would you like a napkin?”

“No. Orange berries. Can’t remember the names.”

“I shall have an assortment prepared directly. Do you believe Lord Astoragon would like a snack, Miss?”

Foliana paused. She looked out the window and spoke distantly.

“No. He’s teaching. No time for food. Too busy shouting, I think.”

“Incorrect!”

Niers bellowed the word. It shouldn't have been possible for a person of his size to project as loudly as he did, but the word rang through the lecture hall.

The student he was yelling at, a young Human man who looked like he was still growing, turned dead white and might have fainted as Niers pointed at him. The tiny Fraerling shouted loud enough so all his students—and the visitors standing at the back of the hall—could hear him.

“A pike square and archers to fight an Antinium army? You'd be lucky to hold your ground for an hour, much less win the battle!”

He roared at the young [Tactician] who'd voiced his incorrect opinion to one of Niers' questions. It was class time and in the large lecture hall, the Titan, or the Professor as he was known to his students, was angry. He was always angry, of late. He felt cooped up, especially because he had to show all these visitors how wonderful and important his classes were.

“The Antinium are *not* a foe to be underestimated! If the last two Antinium Wars have taught the world anything, it is that they are a powerful and unpredictable foe that, yes, uses a stock variety of soldiers with little variation, but makes up for that with unbreakable morale, armored and numberless infantry, and the ability to tunnel! If a third Antinium War breaks out and a Balerosian company is contracted to battle the Antinium, I will see you using better formations against them than *that*.”

He glared around the room, making students shrink down in their seats or stare at their inky notes rather than meet his eyes. No one wanted to catch the Titan's wrath and be called out for their ill thought-out tactics like the trembling young man in his seat.

Of the lot, a group near the front consisting of eight or so individuals didn't flinch from Niers' gaze. They were his advanced students, the ones who he considered able enough to lead his soldiers in an actual battle. Niers studied the group for a moment as his students consulted their notes.

Yes, his best. Some were bright and truly talented, like Umina, a Lizardgirl who was studiously checking her notes despite already knowing the answer. However, she was hesitant and afraid to be bold. Others, like the Dullahan named Cameral were gifted but lacking the creative talent Niers tried to inspire.

Some, like Marian the Centaur and Venaz the Minotaur, were supremely confident in their abilities. Venaz was leaning back in his seat, lounging with a smirk on his face as he watched the others, waiting to be called on. As for Wil and Yerranola...Niers passed over the Human and Selphid. They would field any question he shot at them.

“Countering the Antinium is no simple matter of lining up a bunch of experienced [Pikemen] and having [Archers] whittle them down. Anyone studying the way the Drakes fought the Antinium during the first war would see that static defenses are aggressively overrun by Antinium. They won’t hesitate for a second to run onto a pike and tear the [Pikemen] to bits while their Workers tunnel right underneath the feet of your archers!”

Niers had a huge board on one side of the room which he would write on with the use of a magic quill. The levitating quill shot across the white parchment tacked to the board and sketched out the rough plan of a battle as he spoke. Later on he’d have the parchment replaced, and students could study the lesson at their leisure in another room.

“No, a far more effective tactic is to destabilize their lines with elite shock units while mages bombard concentrations. Aggression to match the Antinium offensive. That is the lesson General Sserys and General Shivertail taught us in both wars. Now, let’s assume the worst. Assume you, as a [Strategist], are left with only pikes and archers as young Nenor has suggested. What is the best strategy in that case? Anyone?”

He looked around, this time eying Venaz and wondering if the Minotaur had any better suggestions than ‘use Minotaurs’ as his arguments. He was about to call on him when a *tap* on one of the windows by his head interrupted him.

Heads turned, and Niers saw a radiant bird with brilliant red and gold plumage, glittering in the morning light, perched on a branch outside of the

classroom. He recognized the huge beak and glittering wings of the beautiful bird and scowled at it.

The Sparklewing Bird ruffled its feathers in the morning air and cocked its head winsomely at Niers as he spoke. It pecked at the glass. He grunted and waved a hand at one of his students.

“Marian. Get a bow and shoot that damn bird. It’s a hazard if there are any Fraerlings about.”

“At once, professor.”

He resumed speaking as Marian got up and trotted out of the room. A few seconds later he heard a *squawk* and the birdsong ceased. Some of the students winced. Niers nodded at Marian as the Centaur trotted back into the room.

“Now, an Antinium army has assaulted your very odd army of pikes and archers. You’ve a few high-level individuals among them, but no one noteworthy. Your terrain is a canyon, with ground porous enough that the Antinium can dig through it. How will you survive their assault? Venaz, speak. And so help me, if you claim your entire army is filled with Minotaurs I’ll send to you to Izril so you can see how well your tactics hold up against the Antinium *in person!*”

As it happened, Venaz had a far more intelligent plan of staggering his lines of pikes and archers, creating a hostile terrain for any burrowing Antinium and pointed out the use of charging pikes as opposed to a static defense. For that, Niers grudgingly awarded him full marks and set the rest of the class to fielding questions about how to handle the Antinium specialist types which the world was aware of.

Then he set them the day’s homework—researching the Antinium Wars and discussing whether a third one would result in the defeat of the Drake cities or northern Human settlements, and what role Baleros might play in

the conflict as potential mercenaries for any side. Niers privately planned to award double points to anyone who considered whether a Baleros company might be hired by the Antinium and discussed the ramifications of such a decision.

Classes were usually like that. Niers had been teaching for a long time and in the lecture-hall sections of his classes, he would give students complex questions and test their knowledge of different species and historical conflicts, not to mention political decisions they might be subjected to. A [Strategist] had to decide the fate of their company outside of the battlefield, after all.

However, today was different in that instead of continuing the lesson with more practical examples as usual, Niers was instead called away to greet some of the visitors who'd observed his class. He bowed over a scaled hand and kissed the tip of a fingernail now.

"Lady Messimar, greetings to you. I hope you find the city of Elvillian hospitable in your sojourn here."

"You are too kind, Lord Astoragon. I was most struck by your lessons—I should hardly like to be the one shouted at by the Titan himself. That poor Human looked like he was about to faint!"

"The students grow used to it with time, Lady Messimar. I assure you, my shouting at them is the least of the challenges any [Strategist] will have to face over their career."

"So very true. And you should know, of course! On a different and far more pleasant note, may I compliment you on your marvelous attire, Lord Astoragon? You've seen the latest designs from Terandria, I take it?"

Niers grimaced as he was reminded of his lace outfit, but he covered it with a courtier's smile.

"Oh yes. I found them...inspiring to my heart, to say the least. May I compliment you on the pairings of your dress, Lady Messimar? Rose and green become you."

The Lizardwoman blushed and swept herself back a step, flourishing the gown of lace and muted colors that was for some reason stylish. Niers made

a show of looking her up and down—as was polite for Lizardfolk, and the Lady Messimar departed after exchanging a few more pleasantries.

“One down, a few hundred to go.”

Niers sighed as he stood on the pedestal that had been placed for him to speak with his guests at eye-level. He felt a presence by his side and nearly spilled the chilled drink he was holding. Foliانا appeared out of thin air, munching on a muffin. It was the same one Niers had seen at breakfast, he was sure.

“Lizardfolk.”

“Don’t point Foliانا, it’s rude. And mingle, remember?”

Niers hissed at the Squirrel tribe Beastkin. Foliانا nibbled at her muffin. She was not wearing lace and neither was she smiling. She looked around at the parade of lace and stiff, polite expressions with clear distaste.

“We have a [General], two [Mages], our best [Sharpshooter], *eight* [Captains] and a bunch of other people I don’t remember. Why do I have to be here?”

“Because you’re the leader of one of the Four Great Companies. Ours!”

“Mm.”

Niers sighed. They were holding this greeting session in a ballroom, a place they’d kept from the palace when they converted it into an academy and paid far too much for. They’d paid gold to have sapphires melted and drawn into the marble flooring, and the curtains! Silk and enchanted, just like the damn windows.

But it was all important. The guests, the meeting, even the polite nothings and wearing the latest fashion trends. Niers and Foliانا both knew it. They raised funding for their company during this time, made valuable alliances and deals. They could receive thousands, tens of thousands of gold pieces in donations from a single one of these guests. Fundraisers were vital. Every big company had one yearly and the biggest had to show they were willing to spend to earn.

“I’m being polite and waiting for people to seek me out. Why aren’t you saying hello to anyone?”

“I said hello to Morn.”

“She’s *our* [Captain]!”

Niers and Foliana spoke as their guests waited for an opportunity to swoop in and engage one or the other in conversation. Not both; that was intimidating. And in truth, Niers was the desired person to meet. The infamous Three-Color Stalker was hard to recognize for many, and her reputation as both a silent killer and oddball preceded her. How Niers envied Foliana for that.

However, there were some for whom the dual personages only added allure. Niers heard a voice, shouting joyfully.

“Lord Astoragon! Lady Foliana!”

A voice called out to the two as they talked quietly. Niers turned, putting on a forced smile and Foliana turned transparent. She reluctantly faded back into view as a Centaur trotted towards them.

The fact that he was a Centaur didn’t matter at all, and was a superfluous detail that everyone didn’t pay attention to except to watch out for his hooves. Niers greeted him and then the Centaur broke into their conversation. He’d probably been listening in.

“Might I compliment you on your outfit, Lord Astoragon? Quite the latest style.”

“Yes, it is, isn’t it?”

By his side, the Fraerling [Strategist] could see Foliana making a face and not bothering to hide it. He smiled so pleasantly his face hurt. Two down, a hundred more to go.

There was no chess game waiting for him when Niers finally got done with the greeting of guests and socializing. He dragged himself back into his room and brightened the instant he saw a piece had moved. But when he hopefully moved a piece—of course, after a great deal of deliberation and restudying the board, although he'd already done so that morning—his opponent didn't move a piece in response.

That often happened. He or she was probably asleep. Niers rubbed at his face and blinked in the candlelight.

“Who set that out? Peclir? Good man. Damnit. I should quit.”

He sat in his bed for a second, undoing the lace and growing annoyed at the time it took. Today had been irksome. Tomorrow would be...dead gods, the banquet was the day after tomorrow, wasn't it? Niers groaned as he lay down and went to sleep.

“Advance!”

Umina the Lizardgirl shouted as a wave of her soldiers collided with the enemy. Her cavalry circled around and struck Cameral's forces from the rear. The Dullahan struggled to keep up with her rapid attacks as the two other spears of cavalry kept circling and hitting his troops in odd places. And while they did, her archers and heavy infantry kept circling, forcing him to keep adjusting his rows of soldiers, stretching, stretching until something broke—

It ended with a shower of arrows hitting Umina's command. It was a stray shot aimed at her in sheer desperation, but one of the arrows filled with dry paint powders struck Umina squarely on the chest and she was knocked out. Reluctantly, she watched as her leaderless army struggled to repel Cameral as he regained control of the battlefield. In the end her forces were routed, although Cameral had lost nearly half of his army in the process.

“It wasn’t fair!”

Marian was strident in the after-battle review, as ‘dead’ soldiers came off the side of the field and healing potions were passed around for those with bruises or, more rarely, broken bones.

“She had him right where she wanted. If it wasn’t for that stray arrow, she *would* have won! How is that fair?”

The Centaur paced back and forth as Niers stood in the shade, marking the positions of Umina’s strategy with figurines. It wasn’t a game, or rather, these practice sessions were meant to simulate actual battles. The hired [Soldiers] and [Actors] could form any number of armies and do battle as two of Niers’ students attempted to defeat each other.

There were low-level [Mages] who could use ‘spells’ which were designed only to mark which soldiers had been killed. And as for charges and actual melee combat—they used padded weapons, but swung them hard and fast. Soldiers would retreat after being killed, but in the thick of things people could still be hurt, sometimes badly.

But Niers paid well. And it was one of the reasons why his academy was so famous. The strategist glanced to one side and saw a lot of his guests watching from the shade of a canvas tent, talking excitedly about the battle.

Almost as excitedly as Marian. Niers halted her in her tracks.

“Cameral, would you like to answer?”

The sweaty Dullahan had his head under one arm. He raised it now, looking slightly ashamed but defensive.

“I was aware I was losing, so I ordered my archers to target Umina. On purpose. I would have done the same in any real battle.”

“But—”

“Just so. Cameral’s tactics were valid, Marian. However, on that note Cameral, I would have begun aiming for Umina to begin with. If there is a fault in how the battle played out, it was that you entrusted that attack to luck, rather than factored it into your plans.”

The Dullahan nodded, looking thoughtful. Umina, still covered in yellow paint, also nodded, but Marian protested again. She trampled her hooves in a mini Centaur tantrum as she spoke anxiously to Niers.

“It’s—it’s unfair! If we have to duck and cower away from every archer —”

“Hah! Speak for yourself.”

Venaz folded his arms. The Minotaur tossed his head as he gestured at the trampled ground and spoke to Marian.

“If I’m on the battlefield, I *expect* to be shot at. Give me a shield and I’ll command from the front!”

“Oh yeah? I’d like to see you dodge a rain of arrows. Give me a bow and—”

“Enough!”

Niers raised his voice before his two most hot-tempered students could get into it. He tapped his foot on the wooden platform he stood on thoughtfully.

“Attacking the enemy [General] or [Strategist] is a valid tactic, Marian. We saw a similar move occur in the recent battle around the King of Destruction. Or don’t you recall how his steward, Orthenon, allegedly targeted the enemy army’s [Strategists] in order to cripple it and bait them into following him into a trap?”

His students fell silent. News about the King of Destruction’s return was hot on everyone’s lips, but news from Chandrar was sparse. Marian bit her lip.

“But professor, how do we protect ourselves from something like that?”

“Well, let me phrase it to you as a question. This is a class. How would you do it, Marian? Anyone?”

The group of [Tacticians] and [Strategist] students fell silent. Then Umina raised her hand. Niers nodded at her.

“I can’t speak for running up against the King of Destruction’s [Steward], professor, but I’d keep my command a lot further back next time even if it meant seeing less of the battlefield. Or wear plate armor.”

There was a bit of tittering at that comment. Niers looked around and shook his head.

“You all think plate armor’s such a bad idea? If Umina *had* been wearing it, she’d have won that last battle.”

Everyone fell silent. Niers sighed.

“Practicality. I keep telling you—in that case, if you’re all willing to stand the heat, I’ll grant any one of you willing to stand around in plate armor an exemption from the first three arrows that strike you at range in a match. One spell too—so long as it isn’t a directly targeted attack on you specifically.”

That produced some murmurs. Each ‘battle’ was an important event. It attracted a lot of attention from the city people who liked watching people beat each other with swords and seeing the latest talent, and it was also the subject of intense betting by students and other groups. More than that, it was how Niers evaluated his students, so any edge or tactic was immediately put to use.

“Just remember that plate armor’s restrictive. You’ll move slower, see less—and a [Strategist] needs to see the battlefield. Like everything else, it’s a calculated risk. Now, Venaz, Marian, you two seem to disagree on how a [Strategist] should behave when in danger. Show me which one of you is more correct. Form up an army—I want an equal match so calculate accordingly. You have twenty minutes!”

Baleros was warm in the winter. Not hot, true, but Niers felt like his doublet was trying to strangle him. He gladly accepted a glass of squeezed fruit juice from Peclir, a tiny thimble in his case—and downed it quickly.

Peclir had a small teacup's worth of juice—a huge tank in Niers' world—ready, and the [Strategist] filled up his cup again with a grunt.

“Thank you, Peclir. Let me know when Venaz wakes up. I imagine being trampled by Marian hurt his pride more than anything, but I'd like to know he's alright.”

“Of course, Lord Astoragon.”

Peclir departed, circulating among the other guests who were speaking with the students. It was another game, the prospective investors speaking to prospective company leaders. Now that he was alone, Niers waited until he saw the teacup move.

“That's mine, Foliaana. Get your own.”

“I'm thirsty.”

“Then get your own.”

Reluctantly, the teacup dipped and Foliaana appeared. It wasn't magic—it was a Skill and her own incredible talent mixing together. A [Mage] would have triggered some of the warning devices Niers carried. Foliaana was deadly because she was all-natural.

“Snappy. Why so angry? More rat crap?”

“Peclir sent someone to clean it up and put down traps, but I found some more this morning.”

“Shame.”

“It's a *danger*, especially with our guests, some of whom are Fraerlings! Anyone who's not a [Warrior] is at risk if giant rats attack them.”

Niers grimaced. That would be a disaster. Especially because his company was beloved by the Fraerlings. They had only one hero whose name was known across the world, and it was Niers. Poor repayment to have one of them killed by a rodent.

“They looked good out there.”

“Did they? I thought you didn't care for these games.”

Foliana shrugged. She had a quarter of a muffin in her paws. Niers stared at it pointedly. It looked stale. Foliana nibbled.

“Mm. Don’t care. Said it to be nice.”

“Hah.”

Niers filled his glass a third time. He sipped. Foliana sprinkled crumbs into his cup. After a while she spoke.

“Still shouldn’t do it.”

“Do what? Quit?”

“Mm. Should stay here. Besides, you’re cursed.”

“I am *not* cursed. That’s a myth, and the company’s official stance is that it’s just gossip. I am not cursed—”

She interrupted.

“Yes you are. You’re cursed. You think you’re an old man and you act like it. I’m distinguished and young. You’re crotchety.”

He scowled and splashed his glass at her. She dodged the small shower of juice in an instant and reappeared on his other side. Niers frowned and wiped sweat from his forehead. He sighed, pulled at the lace around his neck.

“I’m not old. Or rather, I’m as old as you, Foliana.”

“Yes. But you look older. I’m having fun. You’re not.”

“What makes you say that?”

Foliana poked Niers gently.

“You’re not smiling. Duh. Mm.”

There was nothing he could say to that. Niers stared at the battlefield where the [Actors] were cleaning up and felt like he’d done nothing to warrant the cold drink in his hand. He hated to admit it. But he did feel old.

That night Niers went drinking just to spite Foliaana. He crashed a party at one of the academy's drinking spots for students. It was filled with the older ones and after a moment where their hearts stopped for fear he was springing an impromptu exercise on them or a pop quiz—he had done it before—he was welcomed to drink by all.

It was rare Niers let his hair down, not that he had any hair to let down. But he was private, and socializing with him was a rare opportunity for his students to ask him questions about current events they might have not dared to in class.

“The King of Destruction?”

Niers snorted. He had a tiny cup of a potent whiskey in his hand as he leaned against Cameral's mug. The Dullahan nodded his head with his hands.

“We've all heard the rumors, professor. He's taken down three kingdoms in the blink of an eye. Speculation is rife that he'll repeat himself last time, despite other nations being forewarned and prepared for him. Do you think it's possible?”

“I'd hardly like to speculate and make a fool out of myself, would I?”

There was a roar of protest from the students at the table. Venaz put his fist down so hard Niers felt his feet leave the table for a second. Everything bounced. He glared at Venaz and the Minotaur subsided a bit. He snorted and glanced at Marian, who was sipping from a drink and smiling coolly.

“You've clashed with his men before, professor. Don't tell us you have no idea how strong the King of Destruction is!”

“He's clashed with Flos' *women* before, Venaz. Females. There's more females than males in his Seven. In fact, now there's only four, only *one* of them is male.”

Venaz grunted as Marian spoke. He kept his eyes on Niers. The Fraerling sighed.

“You want to know if Flos can do it? Honestly, Marian hit on the sole point right there. His Seven. They launched his campaign last time—we studied this in class—and now he has only four. I believe his success in a new campaign will depend on that one factor...”

He drained his mug and his students leaned forwards.

“—On whether the King of Destruction finds a replacement for his Seven, or possibly, an entirely new Seven to command. If he does, then he may truly be unstoppable.”

“Surely he’s more than halfway there already. From everything I’ve heard of him, the King of Destruction could crush a nation by himself, Seven or not.”

That came from the pale Naga holding a wine glass filled with bubbling black liquid. The dead body lifted the cup and drank. Yerranola the Selphid looked concerned.

The Naga was male, but the person within identified herself as female, which was rare for a Selphid. They usually took whichever gender of body they inhabited.

Niers shook his head, sighing. Yerranola was a good student, and she was one of his oldest still at the academy, but she had the same problem they all did. He explained, feeling weary.

“Legends tend to retell themselves until fact and fiction mix together too finely to separate. Relying on hearsay and rumor is a quick way to overestimate your opponents. They call me the Titan, but you’ll note that I don’t crush my enemies underfoot. Nor do I drink from the skulls of my foes or bathe in their blood as the rumors indicate.”

His students chuckled at the dry joke. Niers smiled for a moment.

“Flos is a man. A [King] of a man, and perhaps one of the most dangerous men in the world for that, but a man nonetheless. He can err. He can fall. But I won’t speculate as to what will happen next. If he continues, Baleros will be part of the future, I have no doubt. Where there is war, companies from Baleros follow.”

It was an old saying and it made the students nod as if Niers had said something profound. He sighed. Then Umina did something unexpected.

“Professor, sir. I was wondering. We’ve never seen you drink. Not with us. So while you’re here, would you like to play a game?”

“Chess? I play enough with you lot in lessons.”

It was known that chess helped [Strategists] level. And because Niers had invented the game—a lie only he and Foliana knew to be one—it was part of his classes. But Umina shook her head and pulled something from under the table. It rattled and Niers saw four dies in a cup.

The table went silent. Niers looked around and had to smile. So now his students were setting traps.

“I wonder who put you up to this, Umina. I suspect Wil or Yerranola.”

The Human and Selphid blushed. Umina hesitated.

“No, it was just me, sir. I thought a game—”

“Oh, gambling? Well, I don’t usually.”

“Please? Just a toss?”

“I’ve got a cup! We could bet some gold on it—”

Wil, the Human, brought out another cup and the other students fished in their pouches for coins. Niers smiled crookedly. To do or not? Well, he was in it now. Refusing would just create rumors. While agreeing...

“One toss.”

The students around the table cheered. Niers held up a hand.

“One. Put the other dies together with Umina’s, Wil. Eight dice...you toss and I’ll toss.”

“And the bet?”

Niers smiled mysteriously.

“None.”

The crowd of students fell silent. The older Fraerling could see the looks of speculation. He didn't care. He remembered, and felt old when he saw the look of anticipation on their faces. It was a legend to them. He had lived it.

"Toss, Wil."

The toss was a decent one. Wil had three sixes, a five, two threes, and pair of twos. He put the dice into the cup and realized that the cup was taller than Niers was.

"I can find some Fraerling dice, professor—"

"No need. Put it right next to me."

Niers watched as the cup was set down. He saw the looks on his students' faces, the stomach-churning anticipation. There was no such feeling in his heart. Niers put down his mug, and stepped up to the dice.

He kicked over the cup holding all eight dice. They clattered out onto the table, bouncing together, stopping. The students looked down and the room went quiet.

"Well?"

Niers looked up at Cameral's suddenly waxy face. The Dullahan shifted his head in his hands and coughed a few times before speaking.

"All—all ones, professor."

All eight dice showed only a single pip. In the silence, Niers laughed. Tiredly.

"Well, I lose. A shame, but a good thing I didn't bet anything, eh? Now, where were we?"

"What? You can't just let us—"

"Another game, please professor!"

They begged him. Niers shook his head, and then held up a hand.

"No dice. A coin toss. Heads or tails. Wil?"

Gold coins were usually embossed with whichever city or nation had minted them. Wil fumbled for one and came up with a copper coin. Niers nodded his approval. Wil flipped it, caught it, turned it over.

“Professor?”

“Heads.”

Wil raised his hand. The room exploded.

“Heads!”

Umina laughed as if Niers had pulled a great trick. The Fraerling rolled his eyes, and then raised a hand. Silence.

“Another one, then. Wil?”

The young man flipped the coin. It rotated into the air and landed. He turned it over and looked at Niers. Now the silence was expectant.

“Heads.”

Again the palm rose. Again the cheer. Niers raised a hand.

“Now again.”

Wil looked at him. The other students looked at him. Now they noticed Niers wasn’t smiling. Wil flipped the coin. This time he caught it, hesitated, and didn’t turn it over.

“Prof—”

“Heads.”

Niers stared at Wil. The young man hesitated, opened his hand. The head of some [King] stared up at Niers.

Silence.

“Do it again.”

Niers was the only voice in the room. Wil tossed the coin up, caught it clumsily. He flipped it onto his arm. Then, without speaking, he cupped it

with his palm and lifted it up, changing the face again without seeing it. When he opened his palm, it was heads.

Every eye turned to Niers. He shrugged. Then he looked at Wil.

“Again.”

The young man hesitated. Niers stared into his eyes.

“Flip it again, Wil.”

He did. The result was heads. Niers nodded.

“Again.”

“Heads.”

“Again.”

“...Heads.”

“And now, three times in quick succession, if you please.”

Niers heard the coin being flipped. The second time, it slipped out of sweaty fingers and landed on the ground. He heard a curse, and then as Wil bent to pick it up, a sharp, indrawn breath.

No one spoke as the young man shakily put the coin on the table. They certainly didn't laugh. One person breathed out. Marian, with wide eyes.

“The curse.”

The word went around the table like a breath of air. Niers shook his head and raised his voice.

“You may have heard rumors of a curse. You may have seen evidence tonight—I am telling you that your eyes are mistaken. Your ears as well, for that matter. There is no curse. I simply do not like to gamble.”

“But—”

“That is all. Now, let's get back to the business at hand. I'm feeling inclined to get drunk. How about the rest of you?”

They certainly did. Niers had them break out a cask of very expensive, very potent liquor that was bordering on poison.

“Firebreath Whiskey. Imported from Izril. Is there anyone who’ll compete with me?”

Niers spoke as the first cup was filled. The table goggled, and then shouted with approval. Venaz raised a brimming cup.

“I’ll drink a cup for every one of yours, professor! One thimble to my glass, how about it?”

There was a challenge in his eyes. Niers grinned, and felt a tiny stirring in his chest.

“That sounds like condescension, Venaz.”

“No, professor—”

“I’ll drink a cup to your cup. Even up.”

The table went silent again. Niers grinned widely and felt a tiny bit alive. Venaz stared down at Niers and then roared.

“Hah! So be it! Clear a space you lot!”

Two tumblers of the whiskey were poured, and Niers could see the liquid, a red mixture that made the eyes water if you smelled it. Venaz took his and tossed it down. He coughed, and then Niers watched the Minotaur’s face flush.

“Even Minotaurs blink at the stuff Drakes come up with. Well done, Venaz. I’ll take mine slower. My mouth isn’t so large.”

There was a laugh, but every eye followed Niers. He had to put his thimble of a mug into the tumbler to fill it. Niers put the mug to his lips and drank down the first mouthful. His students cheered. Then without missing a beat Niers did it to the second, the third—

Venaz’s eyes bulged out of his head. The other students were cheering wildly. They watched as Niers slowly drained the tumbler, sip by sip. Niers finished his tumbler and tossed his mug over his shoulder to wild applause.

He cocked an eyebrow at Venaz, who stared at the Fraerling, still steady on his feet, with sudden unease.

Niers grinned.

“Your turn.”

A little past midnight, Niers looked around and realized he was the last person standing. His students were all passed out on the floor, courtesy of a now-empty keg of Firebreath Whiskey.

He was drunk. He couldn't help it; the fumes were enough to do that, even if he hadn't drunk a drop. And the tumblers sitting around him were proof that Niers had drunk a lot.

Or seemed to. His students had actually stopped him after the second tumbler, for fear he might kill himself. Fraerlings could hold more than their body weight in drink and food; they actually got a bit taller as their bodies stretched to support the extra mass, but alcohol could still kill them.

Venaz had gone down after four cups, Marian, three. The others had fallen in short order as well. Leaving only Niers.

In the silence, Niers lost the smile he'd had for a few moments. He fished around in his mouth and pulled something out. He'd hidden it behind a molar. It was a tiny, tiny little cloth bag with a drawstring.

A small bag of holding. Fraerling mages did good work. Niers emptied it over the side of the table and sighed as he listened to it splash on one of his student's legs.

“It was fun the first time I did it. Years ago. Now? Foliana's right. I do feel old.”

He sighed as he made his way somewhat unsteadily through the Fraerways, back to his room. He looked hopefully at the chessboard the instant

he returned for all that he was drunk. No good. Not a piece had moved. Niers sat down and lit a candle, using a wand to flick fire at the wick.

He sat by the burning candle, watching beads of wax drip down next to his head. Niers sighed, and in the silence, he waited for the chess pieces to move. But they never did. And in the morning he woke and found more rat droppings in the Fraer-ways. Peclir still couldn't find where they were coming from.

The next day Niers started his class loud, engaged, and without a hint of a hangover. His older students, the ones who hadn't bought hangover cures from an [Alchemist], groaned and tried to pay attention. Niers delivered a sermon on the virtues of preparation before battle with the example of the bag of holding completely straight-faced. Venaz overturned his table amid the laughter.

It was a lesson he'd taught countless times. Niers smiled a bit at his student's reactions, but he'd seen the same reactions too many times to count. It was all...so similar.

Lace. Rat crap. Niers was letting his students play chess and wishing he really had quit when one of his students rushed into the room, waving a letter. Wil, looking bleary and not at all apologetic for sleeping through the first portion of class, hurried over to the table where Niers was desultorily playing by himself.

"Sir, professor! You'll want to see this!"

The excitement in his tone was palpable. Annoying. Niers tried not to snap.

"What?"

The young Human man showed Niers a letter, a very fat one marked with salt flecks and other travel stains.

“I regularly correspond with a [Strategist] I’m acquainted with in Izril. He lives in one of the Walled Cities and apparently he’s recently received some very interesting letters himself. He sent me a copy! Please, professor, read it! It’s about chess!”

“Chess?”

Despite himself, Niers took the letter and, with some difficulty, unfolded it on the table. His students gathered around. Niers frowned at the title.

“A ‘newsletter’?”

It was...a chess newsletter. A magazine. A letter to any [Strategists] interested in chess—this one was addressed ‘to the [Strategists] of Zeres’. It was from Liscor.

“I, the humble [Tactician] and student of chess have four games to offer you this week, dear readers. In each, I am sure we will uncover a multitude of lessons to be learnt. Most importantly, we see various strategies matching against each other and I am sure my addition to this letter, a new game of which I have been informed, will also please and delight’. Huh, this Drake likes to write, doesn’t he?”

Umina frowned over the letter. Her eye caught the first page of chess notations and she blinked as she read through them.

“Hold on. This is—this is *good*. Great, even! Professor, have you seen—professor?”

She got no reply. Niers was staring at one of the games. Staring and not saying a word. He could read it. Pawn to D4. Pawn to D5. Knight to F3, Knight to F6. And then...Niers didn’t have to read it to know. Bishop to F4.

“It’s you.”

He whispered it at the parchment. He knew. It was his game. The one he’d played after so long—it was the same game, written down for all to see! His students were exclaiming over it, but Niers was overcome by a different emotion.

“This Olesm. Is he the—the author of these games? Did he play them?”

“No, professor. He says he witnessed a game.”

“Witnessed.”

The word was bittersweet on Niers’ tongue. He knew. Olesm Swifttail. From Liscor. The same place...the same place—

“Professor, have you seen *this*? Look! There’s instructions for another game here! It’s says it’s called...‘Go’. Go? What an odd name for a game!”

“*What?*”

Niers pounced on the second piece of parchment. He tore it away and stared at the drawing of a Go board, the instructions on how to play the game. He turned. His students were staring.

“Well? Don’t just stand there! Get me a quill and ink! And parchment! And stones! Black and white!”

He roared at them and they fled in excitement. In minutes, Niers was drawing out the Go board, placing stones, reading the game.

“Capturing stones...I see. Strings, liberties, *I see!*”

Niers played a game against Umina, and his hands shook as he placed Go stones on the board. He won the game, crudely, but he won it. The second game started as Marian shouted for someone to find more stones so they could play the game.

A new game. A new game.

“It’s *you*.”

Niers stared at the piece of parchment. It couldn’t be a coincidence. This Olesm just happened to see a game he’d played with his opponent, and then...found a new game? It *couldn’t* be coincidence. It was them. They had shown the Drake this game.

They had shown Niers this game.

Something opened up in Niers as he played against Umina, as Cameral took his place, as Niers *lost a game* and his students tackled the Dullahan in a mad rush. He sat back and felt the world blurring in front of his eyes.

A new game. A new world, opened up at his fingertips. They were out there. They knew of new games. *They were in Liscor.*

His heart! Niers clutched at his chest, which alarmed his students. But it wasn't pain or age that was making his chest ache so. It was joy. Pure joy.

This was new. This was brilliant. Niers couldn't see through this game. It wasn't simple. It was *fresh*. He felt like a novice dipping his toes in an ocean of mystery. He felt *young* again.

"Someone find me the address of that Swifttail. Olesm. I'll send him gold—and an enchanted ring myself! Anyone with the creativity to come up with this kind of idea deserves a reward. Class is dismissed. Enjoy this new game."

"Won't you play with us, professor?"

"No."

Niers was smiling. He felt like the years were dropping off. In Liscor. They really were. It was confirmed. And they knew of more than chess. More...he felt like he was ten years younger.

He had to know. This instant. Niers walked through the Fraer-ways until he came to Peclir's working area. He summoned the [Chamberlain] and ordered him to bring him a mage specializing in divination magic.

"I want you to find the cousin of this board. They're magically linked so it shouldn't be difficult."

He gave the [Diviner] his chessboard. The [Mage] bent over it, nodding and carefully touching the small, precious thing.

"Of course, Lord Astoragon. Do you wish me to set up remote surveillance if possible?"

"No. Just show me where it is right now. It's probably indoors—give me a view of the entire room."

The [Diviner] nodded and traced a square in the air. Within the lines of shimmering light, an image appeared, as clear as day. Niers found himself looking down at the chessboard. His heart squeezed in his chest.

It was the other chessboard. Shimmering with ghostly pieces—sitting on...was it a table of some kind? He looked around, frowning. It was in some kind of inn. Was his mysterious opponent travelling? Did they live there?

There was no one in the room at the moment. But the [Diviner] had added sound to the spell. The [Mage]’s eyes were shut with concentration as he tried to maintain focus. Niers heard footsteps, muted voices. Someone was in the inn.

Was it them? Niers’ heart began to beat wildly. He stared at the image. Stared at the board. The footsteps were drawing nearer. In a moment he would know. It might not be them. What if it was? How would he know?

Someone stepped into the picture and Niers’ head jerked. He looked away.

“No. Cancel the spell!”

The [Diviner] did so at once. Niers looked back as the image vanished, panting, sweating, gasping for air as if he’d seen a ghost.

“Lord Astoragon?”

The [Diviner] was clearly worn out from casting the spell, even for a few moments. As he should be, since it had gone around the world. Niers thanked him and went back to his room, holding the chess board in his hands.

“No. No. Not yet.”

He sat on his table, clutching the board, shaking. The Fraerling felt hot and cold, trembling with what he’d almost done. For so long he’d wanted to know. And he’d always known he could find out. In that moment as joy had filled his chest, he’d *had* to know. Only to realize...just now, the terrible truth.

He was afraid.

And sometime that night, as Niers sat with the chessboard in his hands, trembling, he processed the fact that he *was* afraid. He stared at his shaking hands, felt the fear churning in his stomach, and shot to his feet.

“I’m afraid? I’m *afraid!*”

He laughed like a madman. Fear! Actual fear! He felt adrenaline running through his veins, and in the next moment, ran over to the mirror. He stared at himself, a greying Fraerling wearing a doublet with—lace? He sneered at the reflection. His hair was one thing. It was just *hair*. But lace? That was old. And pathetic.

“Damn the lace. Damn insipid Human fashions!”

He tore it off his chest, shredded the clothing, burnt it in a candle. The rest of the mess he kicked off the table. Now half-naked, Niers looked around. His eyes narrowed as he saw the Fraer-ways.

“Rat droppings.”

It was dark, and all the rats in the academy were in their burrow they’d hollowed out in a wooden part of the structure. There were a lot of them. They were big, fat from a life spent stealing from students and living off of pilfered goods. And they were smart too, smart enough to avoid Peclir’s cleaners and not eat the poisoned bait.

They were a breed of intelligent rats indigenous to any place with magic. Some kinds could talk. This lot were smart enough to have hollowed out a huge den in the woodwork, and had harvested wax candles. One was lit near the entrance, a sure sign of rodent cunning. Not that the lighting of it indicated they were *that* intelligent; some of the magical breeds of rodents could breathe fire.

A shadow passed by the candle in the dead of night, making it flicker and dance. The rats, feasting on some dried meat they’d stolen from a larder, paid no attention. And then the lone figure moved.

Niers kicked over the candle. The rats all looked up as one. He drew his sword and grinned.

“Hello. They call me the Titan.”

The next day, Niers’ students sat in class, eagerly expecting their professor. They’d played games of Go all night and were hoping to challenge him. At the very least, they expected him to be in a good mood. And he was.

The visitors to The Forgotten Wing Company were also lined up against one wall, eager to listen to the famous Titan give another lecture. Thus, the hall was packed. They waited for Niers to arrive. And waited. And waited.

He was late. He was never late. A [Servant] went out to find him, and after a few minutes of low conversation, there was a shout. The entire room saw the door to the lecture hall swing open and Niers walked in.

He was naked down to his waist and covered from head to toe in blood. He had a sword in his hands, covered in blood and gore. It dripped onto the ground as Niers walked further into the room.

Someone screamed. Niers had his sword in one hand, and a severed rat’s head in the other. He dragged the head along the ground in the complete silence, walking towards the head of the lecture hall.

Every eye followed the tiny Fraerling as he left a trail of blood behind him on the way to his lectern. His students gaped at Niers. He climbed his lectern and looked around.

“Apologies for the delay. I was attending to a pest problem and was distracted.”

“Sir?”

Marian nervously trotted forwards. Niers grinned at her and she froze in place.

“Marian, good! Take care of this for me, will you?”

He tossed the severed rat's head at her. She nearly dropped it.

"Have someone remove the flesh, but save the bones. I have a mind to turn it into a drinking cup."

So saying, Niers turned to his class.

"My lessons have always emphasized the same things. Caution. Prudence. Adaptability. In that third vein, I would like to state the topic for today's class."

He rested his bloody sword on the lectern.

"Sometimes a [Strategist] must throw caution to the winds. There are times when you, and only you, can deal with a matter yourself. Exercise judgment in those cases. A [Strategist] is cautious, but caution is not the same as cowardice. Good? Class dismissed!"

He addressed the rows of shocked faces at the back of his lecture hall.

"Esteemed guests, I will meet you in the banquet hall shortly. Allow me a few minutes to freshen myself up."

He hopped off of the lectern and found Peclir and Foliaana waiting for him. Peclir looked horrified. Foliaana grinned. So did Niers.

"Get me our tailor."

The Forgotten Wing Company employed all kinds of specialists. A [Tailor] was a must, especially given how many high-profile events Niers had to attend. In this case, the tailor in question was actually of a higher class, and she hurried into Niers' rooms after he'd finished washing all the rat blood off his clothing.

She was a [Stitchmistress], and predictably, one of the String People. Niers knew she was high-level and usually delighted in dressing people up. Today she looked crushed by the weight of the tyrannical lace, which she'd

incorporated into her own dress. The effect made her look like she was half-sewn, which worked for her. Nevertheless, the Stitch-woman looked miserable as she laid out a selection of replacement fabrics for Niers to peruse.

“I can have you in a replacement lace suit in time for the mock battles and banquet—”

“No. No lace.”

The [Stitchmistress] brightened up at those words. Niers stood with a towel in front of the mirror, looking at the drab fabrics and shaking his head.

“I want something flashy. Get me bright colors. Red. And trim it with whatever colors you want, but make it bold and bright and eye-catching.”

“Eye-searing?”

“Even better. I’ll have a hat as well. Something reminiscent of a pirate. With a—an ornament of some kind.”

“What would you like?”

Niers cast around and he grinned as he saw a bird flit past the window.

“The feather of a Sparklewing bird.”

“I can get you a fledgeling’s—”

“No. I want a full feather.”

The [Stitchmistress] sucked in her cheeks.

“A feather that long would be as tall as you are.”

Niers grinned wildly.

“So? Counterbalance it with the hat. Use weights if you have to!”

The [Stitchmistress] looked positively giddy, but then she frowned.

“I have to warn you, this does fly in the face of the current trend.”

Niers laughed.

“Fashion? I’m a former Named Adventurer and the second-in-command to one of the Great Companies of Baleros. They can have their fashion. *I’ll* have my dignity.”

She grinned as he winked at her and got to work.

When Niers entered the ballroom of the academy, carried by Peclir on a silver pedestal, every eye turned. Most of the jaws dropped. The [Grandmaster Strategist] was wearing an eye-catching, eye-searing red overcoat lined with silver thread, over a comfortable, decidedly lace-less shirt and pants which he could move around in without tripping.

His shirt under the coat was brilliant white, and his pants were a dark black, making the coat stand out more. His shoes could have been used as a mirror, but pride of place was the hat on Niers’ head, a sweeping grandiose affair that somehow supported a huge yellow feather that shimmered and somehow stayed stuck in the hat and didn’t drag Niers over backwards as he stood there.

“Nice clothes. Mine are more comfy.”

Foliana appeared as Peclir put the pedestal down in the center of the room. Niers grinned as he felt every eye lock onto him. Suddenly, the rows of lace-covered dresses in their subtle colors seemed downright silly. He looked at Foliana and noticed that she hadn’t changed out of her clothing. Her work clothing.

“The feather’s not practical.”

“I’ll take it off if we have to kill someone. But this? I rather like the coat, don’t you?”

“Professor!”

Umina approached, wearing a concoction of laces and trying not to laugh at his feather. Niers smiled at her.

“Yes, Umina?”

The Lizardgirl hesitated. She looked like she wanted to laugh, but contained it to ask her question.

“Didn’t you tell us that caution and prudence were important, sir? A red coat and a feather—Isn’t that—that sort of obvious?”

He exchanged a look with Foliana. Niers adjusted the hat on his head and spoke for everyone to hear.

“Practicality and caution have their importance, Umina. However, speaking for myself, if I can’t win a battle in fashion, I’d rather be dead!”

He looked out one window and saw his students facing off with both armies. It was Venaz against Wil this time, and both were wearing plate armor in the heat. He saw Umina depart and rush out to speak with Venaz. The Minotaur turned, looked back towards Niers, and then took off his helmet and hurled it to the ground.

Niers laughed. As the wary guests circulated around him, he saw Foliana moving towards a dais near the front of the room. Niers shook hands and then pulled a piece of parchment from his coat that he’d prepared as Foliana appeared at the dais.

It was hard to notice her at first. Peclir had to clear his throat and ring a small bell a few times before people noticed Foliana. When they did, there was silence.

The Squirrel Beastkin stood at the dais, and when she spoke, her quiet voice was magnified by a spell so it was projected into everyone’s ears.

“Mm. A twenty years ago, the King of Destruction launched an invasion from Chandrar. He sent his armies sailing to each continent in the world, conquering, claiming lands and overthrowing kingdoms. He sought to conquer the world.”

Everyone stared at her. Foliana stared ahead, not at anyone or anything, speaking to the air. To herself. To Niers.

“His Seven were legendary. Each one could defeat an army, and his great [Strategist], the Gambler of Fates, Queravia, he sent to Baleros. Here.

He sent his other vassals across the seas, to Izril, establishing footholds, battling his foes. But the world was turned against him and the seas themselves sought to stop his advance.”

Niers could remember the sound of drums. He closed his eyes as Foliaana continued.

“Only one of his fleets reached Baleros. The others were stranded at sea. But it was Queravia who first set foot here. She crushed the port city of Zaland in a day, and established a foothold, though her King’s armies had yet to reach here. But she would not retreat. There she planted the King of Destruction’s banner and challenged all the companies of Baleros. By herself! With only a single army, an advance force! And she held that ground.”

Foliaana’s eyes grew brighter, or maybe the world grew dimmer. Niers could still see the smoke, rising in the distance. It seemed like the skies themselves were black during those days.

“No one could defeat her. No one could kill her or rout her army. Not assassins nor legions of her foes. She defeated Three-Color Stalker, flushed them out of hiding and sent them fleeing, nearly dead of their wounds. She slew the leader of the Armored Legion Company, Grandmarshal Sorolat, and broke both his company and the Flowing Wind Company with her forces.”

The people started as Foliaana spoke and they stared at her. She went on.

“The King of Destruction’s fleets neared and it seemed as though Queravia would receive aid. Baleros prepared itself for a war like it had never seen. However, one last force gathered to defeat her.”

Standing, shouting at the [Captains] and commanders gathered before him. The rain fell and Niers raised a banner. They followed him.

“A Fraerling, the second-in-command of the Forgotten Wing, brought together every company from the marshy cities to the eastern ports and launched an assault on her position. On that day the two greatest [Strategists] in the world clashed.”

A woman's laughter. She lay on the ground and laughed at him, laughed as the dice fell one last time. Niers remembered what she'd said. Every word.

Foliana's gaze focused on him in the silence. Her words were a whisper.

"One survived."

No one in the room spoke. Not one of the richly dressed guests, not the students who'd come in from the mock battle fields, not Niers. Foliana waited for three beats of the heart, and then went on.

"The result changed history, broke the spine of the King of Destruction's invasion. His advance faltered. An army from Rhir broke the Lord of the Skies and his tribes. His people fell like flies against the monster slayers. A Minotaur fleet humbled his forces at sea, and Amerys, his champion [Mage], finally found a city whose walls she could not break in Izril. But it was one Fraerling who stopped him, one hero of Baleros."

She raised a hand and pointed. Niers stood tall, the weight of memories on his shoulders. Foliana nodded as every head turned to Niers.

"Guests and friends, I present to you: Niers Astoragon."

She waited a second more, and then she was gone.

After the applause and having shaken every hand in the room—twice, Niers found Foliana. She was making the *hors d'oeuvres* disappear at one of the banquet tables. He coughed as Peclir put him down and checked his notes. Foliana looked at him expectantly.

"Word for word the exact same speech you gave last year. And the year before that."

Unashamed, the Squirrel woman scratched at her ears.

“The same people keep coming back. I think they like the story. And he’s back this year. Mm. He probably eats muffins too. Don’t you think?”

“On campaign? I doubt he would. From what I know of the man, he doesn’t feast himself and eats like his soldiers.”

Niers had a hard time imagining Flos eating muffins in any circumstance. Foliana shrugged.

“Mm. But when does the King of Destruction eat muffins, then? In bed? It’s important to know these things.”

“Why? Are you planning on killing him?”

“Very hard. But I could do it if he ate muffins. No one’s on their guard when eating muffins.”

“Professor! Sir!”

One of his students was trying to get Niers’ attention. He nodded at Marian as she trotted around a visiting dignitary.

“Marian. Can I help you?”

She smiled nervously.

“We were wondering, professor, whether you’d care to have a mock battle with us yourself on this day. You’ve never had a match, and today... well, we were wondering—”

For a second Niers thought about refusing. But then he grinned.

“Why not? Form an army, Marian. I’ll take you on—”

“Me?”

“You and every one of my students who wants to participate. Go on, get things ready. I’ll be out shortly.”

He saw Marian’s eyes widen, and then she galloped from the room. People who’d casually been eavesdropping instantly headed for the doors and the rumors began to fly. The Titan was about to have a match! He wondered what the odds were.

Foliana looked at him.

“The old you would have said no.”

“Good thing I don’t feel old.”

Niers grinned and swept the hat off his head. He plucked the feather and offered it to Foliana. She took it, looking at it with bemusement.

“For luck?”

“It’ll get in the way of a real battle. You can eat it if you want.”

He left her with that. On the mock battlefield both armies were forming up. All of the [Strategists] and [Tacticians], his students, were lined up in front of their command unit. Over half had armor on. The other half were shouting orders as their army formed up around them.

“Sir?”

One of the [Soldiers] in charge of a battalion of pikemen armed with padded spears jogged up to Niers. He nodded at the man.

“You’ve never had a Fraerling command, have you, young man?”

The young man, who was probably in his forties, grinned at Niers.

“No, sir. But we’ve never had the Titan commanding! I reckon we’ll get on. Where did you want us deployed?”

“Oh, I have a simple strategy in mind. I’ll need two people to carry my pedestal—I don’t fancy being trampled. As for the rest, my orders are simple. Here’s the formation you’ll take at the start of the battle...”

In her nice, cool banquet hall which was now mostly empty, Foliana stood at one of the glass windows and stared out at the mock battlefield. It was swollen with people, over half of whom were onlookers fighting for room.

Someone coughed behind her. Peclir came forward and Foliaana turned. She had a muffin in her hands. It was several days old and stale as a rock. The [Chamberlain] eyed it but made no comment.

“Do you believe Lord Astoragon will be victorious, Miss Foliaana? I imagine quite a lot of potential investors will be interested in the outcome of this little event. It could prove unfortunate if he were to lose.”

“Mm. Yes.”

Foliaana nodded. She watched with her curious eyes as someone blew a horn and both sides moved into action. Niers’ students immediately sent cavalry charging at Niers’ flanks, rains of arrows and spells flying at his army, all boosted by their assorted Skills. She watched as Niers’ army spread out, ignoring the attacks, and ‘dead’ soldiers began to depart the field.

“What’s he doing?”

Peclir was stunned by the display. Niers was advancing, heedless of being overwhelmed. He was being encircled, and still he hadn’t made any moves.

The enemy heavy infantry was about to smash into his own when Foliaana saw a tiny red figure in the center of the mass of his army raise a tinier sword. But his voice was not tiny. He shouted.

“[Vanguard of Terror]! [Covering Fire]! [Rapid Advance]! [Formation: Dodge]!”

He waved his sword and his army shot across the field, taking the first wave of soldiers by surprise. His army moved as one mass, as his designated archers, mages, and so on joined with the common infantry. They hit the group of armored soldiers like a wall. Peclir winced as he saw the group of soldiers that had been sent against Niers’ army go flying. Foliaana put her paws over her ears.

“Form up! Form up and charge!”

Niers’ voice was a howl above the shouting. His empowered army pushed back the soldiers trying to encircle them. Peclir stared.

“He’s using his Skills?”

Foliana shrugged.

“Why not? It’s a battle.”

“One hardly thinks that would be fair.”

“Mm. Nope. That’s the point.”

The students were scrambling to withdraw and form a wall between them and Niers. Foliana saw Niers’ army running across the ground. She waited.

“Big skill. Mm. Come on. Can’t win with [Vanguard of Terror]. Which one?”

She peered at Niers. He was being carried by his command, rushing towards the enemy, fearless. Like always. It didn’t matter that he was in a mock battle. She heard his voice.

“*[Charge of the Strategist]!*”

There it was. Behind Niers, his army *accelerated*. Foliana heard a roar, and this time covered her ears and eyes. When she opened them, after the tremendous clash, she saw the other army running for their lives. [Actors] weren’t paid enough to fight that. She watched as Niers’ army joyfully beat the [Strategist] and [Tactician] students with their padded weapons.

After a while, Foliana found the muffin she’d kept from breakfast a while back. She carefully chewed the very, very stale muffin.

“Showoff.”

Niers was standing on his pedestal, red coat ablaze in the sun. Peclir stared at him.

“When I see him so, I can see him there, Miss Foliana. Right there in your story. And before that. He has been a legend.”

“Mm. He’ll quit when he’s old.”

Foliana nodded. Niers was laughing, she could tell. She couldn't see him or hear his voice, but she knew he was laughing. Peclir turned and stared at her.

“Do you mean he plans on retiring, Miss?”

“Mm. He forgets sometimes. I have to remind him.”

“Remind him of what?”

She smiled. Niers laughed, and Foliana turned. Her eyes shone as she looked at Peclir and grinned.

“We're not old yet.”

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The group of riders raced after the magical carriage on horseback. They'd had to chase hard from their position after it; the pink carriage was known not to slow. However, this group of riders was determined to catch it. One of the Humans on horseback pulled ahead, riding through the freezing wind and urging his stallion to catch the fleeing vehicle.

The lead rider was a middle-aged man whose gravitas came more from his rounded belly than his physique. However, he was a skilled [Rider] and urged his horse onwards, trying to catch the carriage as it shot across the frozen ground ahead of him.

So close! His horse was galloping faster than was possible for any normal, non-magical horse to go. But still the carriage moved faster. It was pulled by spectral horses, which raced through snow and across the winter landscape like the wind.

The man on the horse could sense he had only seconds left of this mad sprint before his horse would tire, or risk injuring itself. He dug his heels into the horse's side and it obliged its master, giving up one final burst of speed—

“Oh, do stop making a scene and get in. Quickly if you please; I'm in a hurry.”

The man on the horse blinked. The carriage suddenly decelerated, putting the now-open door at a level with the horse. And from the dark opening, two gloved hands reached out and *yanked* the man off the horse and into the carriage.

The stallion, suddenly divested of its rider, slowed and looked around in stupid confusion. The other riders shouted, but the carriage sped up again, instantly losing them in a flurry of snow.

Inside the carriage, the middle-aged man, the [Mayor] of the small city known as Leadenfurt, found himself face-to-face with a stern, steely-eyed woman. Her name was Ressa, and she politely let go of him and steered

him into one of the padded seats. The man gulped as he saw a woman sitting across from him.

“Mayor Wullst of Leadenfurt. A pleasure.”

Lady Magnolia sat across from the surprised Wullst, smiling and munching on a cookie. It was one of many on a tray sitting on her side of the carriage.

“Lady Reinhart.”

Wullst remembered himself and tried to bow. Magnolia scowled.

“Do stop. I haven’t the time to make this long; I’m bound for First Landing and I doubt you’d like to be dropped off there. It’s a cold, long ride home, especially without a horse.”

“Yes, milady.”

The [Mayor] sat up, conscious of Ressa, sitting quietly next to him. Staring at him. Not that he was intimidated by the look or the proximity—Wullst had been a veteran [Rider], a soldier for many years and he was an excellent fighter. It was just that you heard stories about Magnolia’s maids.

He cleared his throat.

“Lady Magnolia, I deeply regret taking up your time. It is just that this message you sent to all the cities in the area—”

“What of it?”

“You—you requested soldiers from our garrison. A sizeable force of six hundred assorted horse, infantry and—I understand the wording is ‘puffed-up idiots who can cast at least Tier 3 magic’—”

“Mages. Yes. Was that so unclear you felt the need to catch me?”

Wullst spread his hands helplessly.

“Not at all, Lady Reinhart. It’s just that—is it war? We contribute the annual levy to fight with the Drakes, but this is unusual.”

Magnolia sighed. She bit into the gooey insides of the cookie, which was filled with some kind of jam, and chewed for a moment before answering.

“It’s for the Goblins, Wullst. I intend to raise an army and crush them. I trust you’ve heard by now the Goblin Lord destroyed *two* Drake armies near Liscor?”

Of course he had. And if he hadn’t, Wullst wouldn’t have admitted to it. He nodded carefully.

“A dire situation. Yet the Goblin Lord has a ways to go before reaching any major city, if you’ll beg my pardon. He needs to get past Liscor first, and the Drakes are certain to send—”

“Wullst, I am the [Lady] of this carriage, not you. If you would like to cross your legs, shave your beard, wear a pink dress and some rather uncomfortable undergarments, then you may sit in my place and dictate to me all the things I already know. I’ll even let you eat my cookies if you go that far. Until you are that committed, please do not presume to state the obvious.”

Magnolia snapped at Wullst. The man paled and shut up. Magnolia eyed him, picked up another cookie, and bit into it savagely. She frowned as she chewed.

“Plum. Ressa, were you behind this? Never mind. Wullst, I am not asking for your opinion. I am *telling* you that I intend to raise an army and march it south, to destroy this Goblin Lord. I have requested soldiers from you, and your oaths dictate that you raise the required force or provide me an explanation as to why you will not. Have you one?”

“I do, Lady Reinhart. I beg your forgiveness. I received a request from Lord Veltras not two minutes before yours. He required me send him twice the number of men you had levied—”

“Veltras? Damn him.”

Magnolia scowled, opened the carriage door, and tossed the plum cookie out. She slammed the door as Wullst stirred uneasily.

“I do beg your pardon. But it is simply that we lack the manpower to count ourselves safe if we send nearly two thousand of our own to—”

“Yes, yes, shut up. Very well.”

Magnolia sighed. She flicked her fingers, and then stared at Wullst with narrowed eyes.

“Two hundred. Make them cavalry and the best you can spare. Put any mages you have free on horseback, and have them travel to the place I indicated in my letter. If that is too much, you must petition Veltras because I will have some aid from you. Will that do?”

“Yes, Lady Reinhart!”

Wullst bowed, his heart beating in relief.

“Good. Then get out.”

The carriage slowed. Wullst found himself ejected from the carriage before it had stopped rolling. He nearly fell in a drift of snow, and found himself staring around an empty road. He looked back and saw the pink carriage already accelerating.

He was alone. Wullst shivered as a gust of the winter’s winds buffeted him. He would be glad when the snow began to melt, which should be soon, according to his weather mages. He began slowly trudging back in the direction of his escort and mount. He almost wished he’d had the courage to ask Magnolia for one of her cookies. A plum one sounded very appetizing right now.

The magical carriage sped on, flying over hills, across bridges, northwards, ever further. It seldom slowed, never really stopped. When there was traffic on the roads, it swerved off the road, sometimes crossing frozen lakes rather than deal with traffic. And it never ran into trouble.

Sometimes it ran over trouble, but that was trouble's problem, not Magnolia's.

And now it reached a massive city, a sprawling metropolis that had walls, and had built over said walls to accommodate the vastness of its architecture. First Landing, first and grandest of the Human cities ever built on Izril appeared on the horizon. Its watchful towers kept a vigil to the north sea, built countless ages ago by the Human nobility who had fled from Terandria fearing others might follow.

And so they had. More Humans, who had overrun half of the continent. Now their cities reached all the way to the High Passes, but it was always the north where their treasures lay. The ancient seats of power had been established here, and it was here Magnolia Reinhart's blood-spattered carriage rolled to a stop.

In front of a pair of massive gates, and a mansion that was taller than some palaces, Magnolia Reinhart stepped out of her carriage and stretched. Ressa stepped out beside her, quiet as a shadow.

"Oh, look at the blood. Reynold, have that cleaned later, will you? Was it from that young Wyvern we spotted? I believe I actually felt that one."

The carriage rolled away through the snow, and Magnolia paused in front of the gates. They were three times the size of the carriage and made of neither wood nor iron. The stone bars looked down at Magnolia as she strode towards them.

No one entered the home of the Reinharts without presenting themselves at the gates in person. Not even Magnolia Reinhart, scion of the house. She walked up to the gates and pressed her hand against a dull gem set into the stone.

"I am Magnolia Reinhart. Open."

For a moment nothing happened. Then the doors slowly began to swing inwards. Magnolia walked through them, and Ressa followed.

The flurry of snow had built up around the Reinhart estate. Inside, it was a memory. Magnolia's cold skin warmed the instant she entered her ancestral home, and she saw grass, a detailed walkway, the sloping massive

layers of mansion built ever upwards by generations of her family, and of course, her family.

They awaited her down a pathway of bowing servants. Magnolia strode past the uniformed men and women and occasional nonhumans, ignoring their greetings.

“They must have gotten this ready for me.”

She spoke curtly to Ressa. The maid nodded as she walked at Magnolia’s side.

“They know how much you hate it.”

Magnolia snorted and stared at a curtsying girl who might not have been ten. Then she narrowed her eyes at the older woman, young man, and girl waiting for her.

“Ah, Magnolia! Wonderful to see you at last.”

The woman was the first to speak as Magnolia strode towards her. She looked down at Magnolia from the flight of steps, smiling unpleasantly. She was dressed in an expensive gown of silk, and her fingers glittered with magical rings.

Unlike Magnolia, who had a kind of genteel, relaxed aristocratic air about her, this woman seemed to embrace her own importance. She had commanding eyes, piercing blue and not diminished by her age. For that matter, her face and hair reflected little of her years as well, both being the products of expensive [Alchemist] potions and creams. Her hair was a dark brown, accented by—

Magnolia reached the top of the stairs and someone shoved the older woman out of the way as she was about to speak. The woman stumbled, caught herself, and turned, white with fury. She opened her mouth and realized that Magnolia was striding into the mansion already.

“*Magnolia!*”

Confusion, panic, and fear dominated the two younger Reinharts. One of them stumbled and the other shrieked in outrage.

“She pushed me! That maid—”

“Good job, Ressa. Keep up! Aunt Cecille, wonderful to see you. Get out of my way. Young Wernel, I notice you have a sword. Keep it sheathed or Ressa will do something about it. Is that Damia I hear screaming back there, Ressa?”

“Yes, milady.”

“Excellent. Wonderful lungs. She screams like a banshee, which puts me in mind of my sisters. All four of them. Let’s leave her behind, shall we?”

The two accelerated their pace, forcing Lady Cecille Reinhart to chase after Magnolia while venting her fury.

“How dare you, Magnolia! Is this the way you treat—slow down! Where are you running to? You haven’t returned to your estates for years and—*slow down, I said!*”

Magnolia did not slow down. She rounded a corner of the mansion, brushing past surprised servants, navigating from memory. Cecille hitched up her skirt and ran to catch up.

“The rest of your family awaits you in the parlor. They are demanding —”

“When aren’t they? I haven’t the time to deal with them, Cecille. Make my excuses if you want, but I’ll only be here long enough to grab what I came for and leave.”

Magnolia glanced sideways at her aunt. The woman’s face was red with fury.

“You think you can do as you please because you’re the head of the family?”

“Yes.”

Once again, Cecille was left standing gaping in outrage. She had to hurry to catch up again.

“And what is so—”

“I’m going to meet Grandfather. I need an army, and I intend for him to give me one. You may come if you wish. We’re nearly there.”

Magnolia threw open a pair of double doors and began descending. The wonderful, expensive and exotic carpeting which she’d gone past too quickly to appreciate turned into a sloping hallway of stone leading downwards. Cecille, whose hair was now far too frazzled to comment on, paused as she realized where she was, and where Magnolia was going. She turned pale.

“Grandf—you can’t mean to—how bad is the situation outside?”

“Wonderful. Just lovely, really.”

“Truly?”

“No. Why do you think I’m here?”

Magnolia tapped her foot impatiently as Ressa began walking down the corridor. She scowled up at the woman wavering at the entrance to the passageway.

“Well, Aunt Cecille? Coming?”

The older [Lady] of the Reinharts stared at Magnolia. She looked down at the stone passageway—still lovely craftsmanship, it had been constructed by Dwarves after all—but far older and abandoned compared to the modern mansion above. She hesitated.

And then fled.

Magnolia slammed the doors shut without a word and continued downwards, her shoes clicking as they touched the cold stone flooring. Ressa was waiting for her at the bottom of the ramp and they proceeded past ancient murals on the walls, vistas of past triumphs and defeats—the history of the Reinharts.

It was a very, very long passage because of that. The two women talked quietly as they walked quickly down the hallway, slowly descending further and further below the mansion. A ring on Magnolia’s finger began to vibrate as they walked and she took it off with a grimace.

“I forgot it does that. What an unpleasant time I’m having, Ressa. First I have to see Aunt Cecille, and that spoiled brat of a son she has. Did you see the magic sword he was trying to show us?”

“Just as well I kicked him as we passed. Otherwise I’m sure he would have followed. Your Aunt Cecille’s smart enough not to come down here, but he might actually try to accompany us.”

“Did you? Ah, you’re too thoughtful, Ressa. And you got to shove young Damia. I envy you.”

The [Maid] quietly smiled as she and Magnolia walked. She glanced over her shoulder, back towards the rest of the mansion.

“The rest of your family won’t be happy about this. I’d expect the entire lot to be waiting for you when you’re done.”

“They’re never happy, Ressa. And they probably never will be. So what? So long as I get what I come for, I’ll be happy enough to kick whomever I please afterwards. Now, let’s be ready. I hate meeting the old man and today I’m going to ask a lot from him. This will be tough enough without worrying about my lovely relatives.”

They had arrived. Magnolia strode into a different room than all the others she’d stormed through in the last few minutes. Here she stopped. For in this place, at the bottom of the Reinhart mansion, sudden movements might see you very dead.

A brief description of the Reinhart estate proper would be helpful in describing this room, for it was everything the mansion was not. If richness in every variety and excess was the theme that had been used to decorate the mansion by rich, if not particularly tasteful individuals, the theme of this underground room was magic.

And danger. A double line of runes formed a circle around the entrance to the grand room, and a slight shimmer in the air marked off a field that Magnolia did not approach. Beyond the magical boundaries lay—well, one word for it would be an armory.

Or a hoard. If Ryoka Griffin had been in this room, she would have felt a similarity between this room and the hoard of Teriarch the dragon. True,

the rows of floating magical weapons, bookcases full of sealed magical scrolls and other lists of rare and valuable artifacts spoke of a greater deal of organization and attention to detail than Teriarch's amiable splendor, but it was nevertheless a collection of wealth beyond most people's wildest dreams.

Magnolia, who dreamed of confectionaries, was not impressed. She tapped her foot and then raised her hand and rapped on the invisible force field blocking her from the rest of the armory. Ressa, standing at her side and looking wary, winced. The unflappable maid was tenser here than she had been at any time during their long journey.

Her mistress was not. She raised her voice and cupped her hands to her mouth and shouted.

"Hello? Anyone there? Grandfather, I know you're listening! Come out already! I haven't got all day!"

Ressa shifted uncomfortably.

"Magnolia. Maybe it would be best to wait—"

"Give the old man a second to insist on ceremony and make an entrance and we'll be here all day, Ressa. Old man, I know you're out there! Come here, you pretentious lech!"

For a moment, all that could be heard was the sound of Ressa swallowing. Then—footsteps. They came from a part deeper in the armory, where eyesight began to blur. Someone began walking towards Magnolia and Ressa. Had he been standing there all along? Or had he been called by Magnolia's voice?

An old man walked into the center of the armory and stopped in front of the barrier that separated Magnolia from the rest of the room. He was old, yes, but hardly old enough to be called 'grandfather'; he was in his mid-sixties and looked spry although it was true that his head of hair was almost completely grey.

He was dressed in a fashion that had gone out of style centuries ago, and was so old that it would have been trendy by today's standards. That was because fashion was cyclical, not linear. But age was not, and so the man's

eyes contained a depth to them that few other beings possessed. An agelessness similar, but not akin to the look in Ivolethe's eyes, or Teriarch's.

Four attendants, all young women, seemed to materialize from the back and came closer, spreading out around the room, flanking the old man. They were clearly [Maids] as well from the way they dressed, but they too were garbed in a style far older than the plain black and white Ressa was wearing. They nodded to Magnolia's maid and she nodded back, as one did to fellow workers in the same trade.

The old man and Magnolia faced each other across the magical divide, locking gazes and then looking each other up and down. He peered at her with a frown, and then spoke.

"Young Magnolia. I should have known it would be you, girl. Only you would have the audacity to address me so casually."

Magnolia snorted.

"As if your detection spells didn't warn you I was coming the instant I set foot in the manor. Let's dispense with the meaningless pleasantries, Grandfather. You know why I'm here."

"Manners, brat. Or have you forgotten who it is you're speaking to?"

The old man stared down at Magnolia imperiously. She sighed, and gave him a very fake, very unconvincing smile.

"Oh, forgive me great uncle Regis. Or is it great, great, great, great, great, great, *great* uncle Regis? A few hundred more greats? Would you like me to say that every time we meet?"

There was a snigger. It did not come from Regis. One of the attendants covered her mouth. Regis turned red and half turned to look at her before rounding on Magnolia.

"I am your honored ancestor, girl!"

"And I don't care, you puffed up ghost."

Ressa watched the interplay between Magnolia and Regis, whom she called Grandfather because Great Uncle was equally as incorrect. Ressa

would never have dared to be so impolite to him on the other hand. She could sense the enchantments on this room, and they were making her sweat.

Detection spells, truth spells, and so many protection spells that Ressa felt like she were standing in front of a wall made of magic, for all it looked like a few glowing runes on the floor. But that was intentional. The real proof behind the magic contained in this vault lay in the old man himself.

He was dead. He had died over three thousand and eight hundred years ago in this very room. But his memory lived on, as perfect a reflection of the soul as there was in this world. Regis Reinhart stared at his grandniece of countless generations with a frown of annoyance on his face.

“You are impertinent, unruly, rude—which is still better than your cowardly relatives, I must admit. Do you know that they haven’t dared set foot down here since you left?”

Magnolia smiled.

“I didn’t know, but I’m not surprised. They don’t like being reminded that you’re here. The dead should stay dead in their eyes, especially if the dead know all of their mortal foibles and failings.”

Regis laughed shortly. Yes, he was dead, but he was alive in this room. A miracle of magic, or rather, one specific kind of it.

“You children. When did necromancy become such a horrific thing? When I was young, [Necromancers] were as valuable as diamonds! And if your family had a lick of sense between them, they’d realize that someone who’s lived for thousands of years might have some decent advice in his head to share with them!”

“Especially one who delights on spying on them and everyone he can.”

The old man bridled at the implication.

“What I do is to safeguard—”

“Yes, yes. Your time honored duty and all that. It doesn’t excuse what you do, old man. How many scrying spells do you have built into this place anyways?”

He grimaced.

“Not enough. The outside world is a complex place to keep track of, as you well know, girl. And my descendants within the estate are hardly valuable sources of information. They spend their time lazing about, bickering, and not doing anything of worth. That inbred lot is useless to pay attention to unless I wish to keep up with ballroom gossip.”

Magnolia smiled, although it was so bitter it couldn't really be called a proper smile.

“Useless, yes. Inbred—no. I'm pleased that we've saved ourselves from that issue quite handily by entertaining prostitution, scandalous affairs, and if my wonderful family can rise up to the challenge, harassing the hired help. The Reinhart legacy is free from that issue for a few generations, at least.”

It was Regis' turn to smile sourly.

“Tell that to Wernel and his half-sister, Damia. They quite enjoy each other's company. Unbeknownst to their aunt, I might add.”

There was a pause. Ressa saw Magnolia's face twist.

“Ew. I shall have a word with Cecille about that. Please do not inform me of the other indiscretions of my family, Grandfather Regis, or I believe I won't sleep tonight.”

“As you wish. Tell me why you have come then, and I shall decide whether it was in vain, or not.”

Regis crossed his arms and his attendants came forward. Magnolia nodded. Now she was completely serious. She stepped closer to the barrier that kept Regis' memory in the world and spoke.

“I, Magnolia Reinhart, do return to my ancestral home to claim the right of my blood. I ask for relics of the past for war and protection, to protect the lands our family has claimed, to destroy our enemies, and safeguard our legacy.”

Regis' eyes glittered as he stared down at her.

“You have proven yourself a worthy scion over the decades you have ruled the family, girl. You have protected our name and returned more riches to this vault than you have taken. More than the other unworthy descendants of our house. So you may take what is needed. What is needed—and no more.”

His voice echoed through the room, and there was an acknowledgement. The barrier surrounding Magnolia and Ressa faded. Magnolia stepped forwards, and then she was standing in front of Regis. He reached out and grasped her by the arms, smiling down at her. She kicked him.

“Enough, old man.”

Regis’ face contorted and he grasped at his shin as Magnolia strode past him. His attendants hurried to his side as Ressa stood where she was. She knew better than to try and enter the armory.

“Ungrateful wretch!”

“We do this every time. Take what’s needed? Hah! The motto is ‘give more than you take’, you greedy fool. By rights I should walk out of here with a quarter of the contents of this armory in a bag of holding, rather than let you keep it.”

Magnolia strode past him and the attendants who’d been preserved along with Regis. To her, they were as real to the touch as they had been in life, and clearly felt the same, too. Only in this place, though. Ressa looked at Regis as one of the women helped him up and then she looked away. When Regis Reinhart had made the sacrifice to keep his soul here to safeguard the Reinhart treasures, he’d insisted on four [Maids] being preserved with him. The reason was obvious, and both Ressa and Magnolia detested the old man for it.

But he was the guardian. And though Magnolia picked up swords and looked through scrolls on shelves as Regis swore and limped after her, she could take nothing out of the armory without his consent. Which is why they began arguing again in the center of the room.

“I should ban you from this place for a decade for your disrespect—”

“Save it. You know as well as I that I’m owed whatever I need.”

Regis growled.

“In times of need! You can’t simply remove artifacts whenever you feel like it, as I’ve explained to your sisters and brothers time and time again! If there’s a war, I’ll let you have what you need. But to my knowledge, there’s no war going on. Just more infighting, assassinations, a Goblin Lord—”

“That doesn’t count as a war anymore? My, how the times have changed.”

“On the contrary.”

The specter scowled as one of his attendants faded from view and came back with a drink in one hand and a map of the continent which she hung in the air. More ‘features’ of the enchantment that held him. Ressa was of the opinion that Regis had turned his sacrifice into a very enjoyable form of immortality as well as a way to safeguard the Reinhart legacy from greedy future generations.

Now Regis sipped at his drink, not deigning to offer Magnolia one. She could have drunk it too, for what passed into the armory became part of it. One of Regis’ requirements was for several barrels of the finest vintages to be rolled into this place every year.

Regis sighed as he wiped a bit of liquid from around his mouth with a napkin and then indicated the map.

“A Goblin Lord has, and ever will be a threat. Not one necessarily worthy of a Reinhart, but I have heard of these assassinations too, child. They trouble me. The Circle of Thorns haunted your grandmother, and though I gave her aid, she died with their curse still yet lingering over the family. For that hint of danger alone I would give you something.”

“Good to know you’re keeping track of things.”

Magnolia nodded as she sat down in a seat one of the attendant ghost maids brought for her. She tapped a foot on the ground, not disturbed at all by where she was. Regis sat too.

“So you come for what? Detection spells to find the master of the assassins? Guardians to protect you?”

“I have Ressa for that. Don’t scowl, you know she’s capable. No, I need an army and arms against the Goblin Lord, Grandfather. You know he’s a threat. He crushed two Drake armies recently. Had you heard of that?”

Regis grimaced.

“No. I’ve been working to establish new informants, but it is passing difficult when I lack a body and must conceal my nature! I would have heard in time doubtless, but—how many in each army? Did they work together? What was their leadership?”

“Two Drake armies, one led by a Gnoll and the other a Drake from a Walled City. Both high-level [Generals]—”

“Hah! High level by your standards perhaps.”

“*High* level, and commanding strong, experienced warriors. They worked together, old man. Both armies were ten thousand strong. Not a huge force, I will admit, but they went into the mountains hunting the Goblin Lord and were completely defeated. A single [Scout] made it out of the massacre and said they were wiped out to the last Drake.”

Silence. Ressa saw Regis swallow a mouthful of his drink, no longer looking content.

“That changes things. A Goblin Lord that just won a victory is dangerous. His army will grow stronger and replenish itself in days, whatever the losses he took. And with that, he grows one step closer to becoming a Goblin King. You were right to come here.”

He got up and studied the map of the continent. It was old, but most of the geographical locations were unchanged.

“The Goblin Lord was south of Liscor the last I heard. I assume that’s where he fought? He’ll come north, I agree with that, but perhaps he’ll get bogged down around Liscor. It’s winter, isn’t it? If you wait, come spring the valley will be impassible—”

“He’ll come north before that, I’m sure of it.”

“How do you know?”

Regis frowned at Magnolia as she stood up. She calmly traced a line past Liscor north. There were no cities listed on the map around there; when Regis had been young, the Gnolls had occupied the north as wandering tribes.

“They won’t attack Liscor. Goblin Lords aren’t idiots. He’ll march right past and start sacking cities, and then spring will roll around and he’ll be trapped on the north side as *our* problem.”

“An intriguing conclusion. May I ask—”

Magnolia tapped the city of Liscor on the map, one of two gateways between north and south. In the days when Regis’ map had been made, a Dwarf city had stood in the High Passes. Now it was lost to time.

“The Necromancer couldn’t bring down Liscor’s wall in a month. The Antinium couldn’t do it either, and every time we send our armies down to battle the Drakes in the Blood Fields in the time honored tradition of wasting lives for no gain, we ignore the city. Because it is too difficult to take without a truly powerful siege weapon, a massive army, a magical artifact, or a being of immense power.”

“Like a Dragon.”

Regis folded his arms, and suddenly, with the obsession of an old man who enjoyed harping on the complaints of the young, glared at Magnolia.

“Why don’t you have that scaled disgrace of a lover you trusted with do your dirty work for you, girl? I’m sure he’d make quick work of a Goblin Lord—if he ever bestirred himself from his caverns, that is!”

Magnolia turned and scowled at him. Regis retreated out of kicking range.

“You know as well as I that if I asked Teriarch for help he’d refuse. And I don’t expect to be lectured on my private affairs from *you*. Insult me or Teriarch again and I’ll dispel your damn enchantments and break this armory open to rest your departed soul, *dear Grandfather*.”

“Hah! You wouldn’t dare try, brat! Reinharts of the past have broken themselves against the enchantments that keep me here!”

The old man smiled smugly and folded his arms, supremely confident. Magnolia, who breathed the stuff, smiled nastily.

“My ‘scaled disgrace of a lover’ as you put it, has informed me that he would certainly be able to dispel or *destroy* the enchantments protecting you, oh loving grandfather of mine.”

Regis Reinhart paled.

“You wouldn’t. And he wouldn’t dare! The risk—”

“Oh, he’d risk it. For half the treasury. I told him no, as I don’t plan on giving away half of the Reinhart legacy to sit in his caves for him to gloat over. But tempt me, and I’ll see how fast he can teleport over here.”

The threat seemed to stun Regis for a moment. He made an inarticulate noise.

“Enough of this. The Dragon may rest and sleep himself into oblivion. I’d rather he stayed there in case the Necromancer returns. You haven’t told me what you’re planning on doing with him. The rest of the continent may sleep at ease believing him gone, but you and I know he’s a threat.”

“Why, I plan on dealing with him just as soon as I deal with the Antinium. Which, I may remind you, you failed to anticipate being a threat. ‘Leave them alone and the Drakes will handle it’, I believe you said.”

“Don’t quote my errors, girl—”

“And don’t lecture me on Az’kerash, you fool. I know he’s a danger, but I also know that a [Necromancer] may only raise a single army, however strong he is. He can split that army, but it’s hardly as dangerous as six Hives which can overrun countless cities.”

Magnolia tapped the map where six points had been marked around the south eastern part of the continent.

“Kill one Queen and the rest will lead her Hive. Kill the [Necromancer] and his undead lose their master. I’ll kill him when I’m ready or when he

makes a mistake. I have more than enough to deal with now.”

“True. So this Goblin Lord. I’m prepared to give you a good deal child. You have contributed to the Reinhart family, I will admit, so what you need is yours. Name it.”

Regis waved a hand regally and his attendants stepped forwards with swords, rings, magic scrolls and other objects of power in their hands. Magnolia looked around dismissively and then pointed.

“I’ll have that. The Crown of Flowers.”

On a pedestal across from her sat a laurel wreath made of glowing flowers. When Magnolia spoke one of the attendants dropped the sword she was carrying. Regis nearly choked on his drink.

“What? *No!* What would possess you to—out of the question!”

“You said what I wanted.”

“*Within reason!* That is one of the three great treasures of this armory! If I let you have it again—anyways, its power is weak in the winter.”

“Its power is sufficient to end any Goblin threat old man, winter or not. Give it to me and I’ll not ask for anything more.”

Regis scowled at Magnolia.

“If you were going to conquer the continent, I’d let you have it. Or if there were a genuine Goblin *King*. A Lord doesn’t warrant that artifact, not by far.”

“What about a Great Goblin Chieftain? Ever heard of one of those, Grandfather? One appeared in Dwarf halls Rest. Apparently it’s been living there since the last Goblin King fell and it fought for the Goblin King.”

“A Great Chieftain? I’ve never heard...no, perhaps there were some...I do recall one or two over the years.”

Regis floated away from Magnolia, forgetting to walk for a moment. His form grew misty and transparent as he thought.

“I do recall such Goblins, though rarely. They are akin to Goblin Lords, but lack the drive to be Kings. Thus, they are dangerous. You say one has been here without your knowledge?”

“And it seeks to join the Goblin Lord. The Goblin *Lord*, great uncle, who may well be a King if left unchecked.”

“More and more reason why you should finish him quickly. But not with the Crown of Flowers.”

Magnolia sighed, but Ressa knew that the Crown of Flowers had been a long shot anyways. Magnolia turned back to the map.

“Very well. I’m currently levying soldiers from every city from here to Invrissil. I intend to form an army and attack this Great Chieftain first, and then the Goblin Lord.”

“A sound plan. How many soldiers...?”

“Forty thousand, give or take. Hardly as large as the armies we send to fight with the Drakes each year, but enough for a Goblin Lord.”

“Assuming he hasn’t grown too large. Have you a [General] for this army, or do you plan to lead it yourself like you did as a child?”

Magnolia folded her arms and stared icily at Regis.

“I have a [General] in mind that is more than competent. But I require arms for him, soldiers from my estate, and more artifacts besides. Give them to me.”

Regis gritted his teeth, seeming to calculate unseen odds and numbers before nodding.

“What do you want?”

“I will have forty thousand soldiers and a [General], grandfather. Give me two companies of our own warriors and some battle golems. Armor fit for a [General]—he won’t need a weapon. And a magical artifact to deal with this ‘Great Goblin Chieftain’. Oh, and give Ressa a dagger.”

The guardian of the armory pursed his lips, looking put out by Magnolia’s demands. He glanced at Ressa, who stood straight and returned

his gaze as it probed her. Finally, grudgingly, he nodded.

“It will be done. I will give orders. You may take two companies of [Knights], armed with minor magical artifacts. I will give you the armor of your forebears for this [General], and three battle golems. Your maid—”

“Gets a dagger. Or a shortsword. She can use both. But it has to be concealable.”

“Assassins. Bah. Very well, I will grant her the Keing Dagger—”

“That’s a poor artifact. Give her the Yawning Blade, you cheapskate.”

“For her? No. She may have the Vision of Grasses and I will expect it returned when this business is done.”

Regis pulled a dagger out of the air and handed it to Ressa. The blade was curved and tinted green, and tapered off into a cutting edge that eyes alone could not see. Ressa bowed as she accepted it and took exquisite care not to let the edges touch any part of her body.

“There. As for this artifact you require—I will give you one that can dispose of the Great Chieftain personally. One moment.”

Magnolia waited and found herself being handed a tube with countless symbols etched into it after a moment. It looked like a very cylindrical vase, or an over tall cup of some kind. She dubiously stared into it and the attendant who’d given it to her snatched it back.

“*Please* treat it carefully, Lady Reinhart. This device will activate if you will it, and it is capable of felling a Giant.”

“A shame that they were all wiped out, then.”

Magnolia took the tube back and tossed it up in the air. Then she caught it and pointed it around, aiming casually.

“How do I—? Oh, yes, I see. I just have to think and it’ll trigger, correct? How very handy. I can’t wait to see what it does.”

She swung the tube carelessly, aiming it around the armory. *Everyone* ducked, including Regis. He roared at her as Ressa picked herself up from the floor.

“*Careful* with that, brat! Do you know how many of your ancestors have died from magical artifacts they’ve used improperly?”

“Not many if they had to get them from you, great uncle. Now, I’d love to be going soon, but I felt I should mention one last thing. While I was requesting soldiers, it came to my attention that Tyrion Veltras is doing the same. It seems he intends to raise an army to deal with the Goblin Lord, although he was quite content to leave them alone earlier.”

Regis’ face purpled as he got to his feet. He roared, making his attendants clap their hands to their ears.

“The *Veltras*? Those lowborn dogs want to steal glory and a march on our family? Why didn’t you tell me before? If you had, I’d have given you all that you asked without arguing!”

Magnolia smiled sweetly.

“Because now you’ll give me everything I asked for and more, grandfather. Or would you like Tyrion Veltras to be the one responsible for defeating both the Goblin Lord and this Great Chieftain?”

Regis stared at Magnolia, eye twitching. Ressa saw one of the attendants—two of them, actually—giggling, and wondered if their long years of imprisonment here were bearable after all. She hoped so, for their sakes.

As for her, Ressa looked at her mistress as she stared down her immortal ancestor. He glared at her, swore, cursed her mother and her mother’s mother, all of whom had dealt with him before, and then, surprisingly, smiled.

“You’re an impertinent brat. You always were. I suppose this is why you make for such a good head of the family, though. It’s children like you who make me think we’ll take this continent yet.”

He smiled fondly at Magnolia, who rolled her eyes. Ressa sighed too, as Regis began to speak about Magnolia’s great, great, great, great grandmother.

Visiting the family was always a tiresome affair.

They left the estate in good time after they parted with Regis. He had Magnolia's soldiers and arms ready when they left. The family wasn't trouble either. When they saw Magnolia coming out of the stairwell with the magical artifact of devastation pointed right at them, they fled.

"Aunt Cecille? A word as we leave."

Magnolia called out to one of the women fleeing the range of the tube she was holding. She handed it to Ressa, who cradled the deadly artifact with a great deal more care than Magnolia. The two women strode on.

"Before I deal with Cecille, have word sent to Lady Bethal, Ressa. I know her Knights of the Petal are quite good. I'd like them to hunt down that other Goblin Chieftain—you know, the one that's been waylaying travelers on the road?"

"By herself?"

"She has Thomast. He could probably outduel any Chieftain living, and if worst comes to worst, Bethal's intelligent enough to retreat. However, I think that her knights will make short work of the problem. She's to join me at Dwarfhalls Rest later. We will bring down the Great Goblin Chieftain as soon as I can march the army all the way there. Argh, but it'll take forever. A shame I couldn't borrow the Banner of Terland but—he'd never let me have it."

"First the Great Goblin Chieftain and then the Goblin Lord. In quick succession. You aren't waiting for them I see."

Magnolia smiled coldly. Regis had the eyes of a being who'd lived for thousands of years, but Magnolia's eyes were more distant still.

"I don't play games, Ressa. I have assassins to deal with, the Antinium, Az'kerash—and now this issue of otherworlders that Regis doesn't know about. I can't waste time on a Goblin Lord."

She paused and then kicked at one of the walls, speaking loudly at the ceiling.

“You hear that, old man? Time to broaden your scrying! There’s more at stake here than the continent and you had no idea until I told you about it! Guardian of the Reinhart legacy my *foot!*”

A loud curse echoed through the mansion, making Lady Cecille cower as she scuttled up to Magnolia. The head of the Reinhart family sighed and walked on. Ressa followed, smiling slightly.

The mighty planned and made preparations for war. That was how it was. That was how it always was in Izril. Unlike Baleros, where war was more like endless conflicts between mercenaries and seldom engulfed the entire continent, or Chandrar where it happened between kingdoms, more rarely in the deserts, Izril had only one war. That of the Drakes and the Humans.

Oh, and the Gnolls of course. The tribes were always an issue. And the Antinium, damn them! And if it came to that, the Goblins were a threat. But to Drakes, the threat had always been Humans. Always. They had landed on their shores millennia ago, and Drakes never forgave the land they had ceded to the Humans. Never.

Terandria had politics. Rhir struggled for survival. But Drakes had a foe. Those damn Humans. It was more of a bad rivalry now, true, as neither side did more than send armies to the Blood Fields each year to kill each other. But give them half a chance and the Drakes would happily invade the north, while the Humans would do the same.

That was why Drakes were ready for battle. And in Liscor, the council—a group of individuals who represented different facets of the city from the Captain of the Watch to the [Strategist] that was required by law to be present in case of emergencies—knew what to do. Or rather, they knew what they were supposed to do.

Olesm Swifttail sat around the table, feeling very nervous and very, very unsure of himself. Drake law was clear and it outlined the steps a city should take in cases like now. But unlike a Human invasion which would mandate instant support from every Drake city on the continent, the situation with the Goblin Lord was different.

He had crushed two armies sent against him. Two. Armies. Both had been led by famous generals. Thrissiam Blackwing and Garusa Weatherfur were *legends* to Olesm. The thought that they'd both fallen in battle made him fear for his city.

He was just a [Tactician]. Hardly qualified to make decisions about the city. And the Council—well, Olesm didn't like to badmouth fellow Drakes, but they were only a nominal ruling body that took care of bureaucratic measures. They weren't *leaders*.

And they were all Drakes. Olesm would have loved to have Krshia in the Council rather than the appointed Head Merchant, a Drake with less experience than the Gnoll. But politics were politics. Of the group, the few people who seemed in control and knew what to do were Watch Captain Zevara, Wall Lord Ilvriss, General Zel Shivertail, and the Named Adventurer, Regrika Blackpaw.

It was reassuring to have them all here. Very reassuring. Olesm thought the other Council members would have panicked if it weren't for such legends being in the room, reassuring them. They might have panicked anyways, but there was another factor keeping the room somewhat calm.

The Humans. The Human, in point of fact. Jelaqua Ivirith and Ulrien Sparson were both here, but Olesm knew for a fact that Jelaqua was a Selphid. But to the other Council members it probably didn't matter. Jelaqua looked like a Human, so she counted.

Thus, the prevailing mood was nervousness, but hidden by bravado. Yes, the situation was grim. However, you couldn't let the Humans see that, could you? Had to put on a brave face. Yes, stiff upper tails and all that. It seemed the other Drakes were reminding each other they had to stay calm in front of the Humans.

"I think we're agreed, then."

Wall Lord Ilvriss spoke as he leaned over the table, and Olesm sat upright guiltily. He'd been dozing off—the meeting had gone on for hours. Ignoring the guilty starts of the others in the room, Lord Ilvriss summarized the main points they'd discussed.

“Word has already been sent to the other cities. I expect my city will send another army—a larger one—to destroy this Goblin Lord in due time. No doubt it will be a confederation army after all. However, in the meantime Liscor must stand. To that end, a message spell has been sent to Liscor's army.”

“Which isn't here because...I don't get that bit.”

Ilvriss turned and glared, only half-acknowledging Jelaqua's bright smile. Zel cleared his throat and nodded at the Gold-rank adventurers. They were awarded a place at the meeting due to their experience, although neither Ulrien nor Jelaqua had spoken much up till now.

“Liscor's army is a mercenary one. They spend months, sometimes years in the field, earning money. They're exceptionally good at their job—with them here the Goblin Lord could assault the walls and would definitely fail to seize the city.”

“However, they're too far away to return and preoccupied with fighting. They have agreed to send a unit to defend the city. They should arrive...in time.”

Zevara gritted her teeth and lashed her tail. Olesm winced. The reply from Liscor's army had been short, concise, and unhelpful. But that was the relationship between city and army. It was always strained.

Ilvriss cleared his throat, looking annoyed at the interruptions.

“In the meantime, we shall prepare the city for attack. If it comes to it, we can hold the walls long enough for reinforcements. However, I doubt the Goblin Lord is foolish enough to besiege us. If he is...”

If he was, it was war. Olesm swallowed hard and looked around the room. The plan was good and simple and it had mostly been politics argued over so far. However, no one had brought up the white Dragon in the room

and Olesm was afraid that if he didn't speak now, he'd lose the nerve. Cautiously he coughed and raised a hand.

Instantly, every eye was on him. Olesm felt himself pale as Zel Shivertail himself looked at him, but he stood and spoke hoarsely.

“Begging your pardon Wall Lord—”

Ilvriss nodded graciously at Olesm, smiling a bit. He had been very nice to the Drake, which was at odds with all the things Erin and Ryoka said about him. Olesm continued, speaking to him and Zel.

“—But what about the Antinium? I understand that if it comes to a siege, the Antinium are called upon to defend the city. However...”

Ilvriss' smile vanished and Zel shifted. The two Drakes looked at each other as the council room fell silent. Yes, the treaty clearly spoke about Antinium aiding the city. But they had only done it once, when Skinner attacked. And the feelings the two Drakes had about the Antinium were abundantly clear.

“If it comes to that young Swifttail, we shall...apprise the Antinium situation as need be.”

Ilvriss spoke to Olesm, but, the Drake sensed, to Zel as well. The [General] nodded.

“They may be helpful. If not...”

Another silence. If not, it might mean another war, far worse than any war with a Goblin Lord. Olesm looked around and sank into his seat. Now he was wishing he hadn't brought up the issue, because he was *really* worried.

“If it is the Antinium that concerns you, perhaps it would be best to focus on the Goblin Lord as a threat first, yes? A known enemy in the trees and one underfoot is better than a shadow on both sides.”

Someone else spoke up. Regrika Blackpaw leaned over the table, larger than life, a giant of a Gnoll. She smiled reassuringly at Olesm and he found himself smiling in return. Ilvriss nodded.

“True. I would like to know how our warnings about the Goblin Lord were ignored so badly both armies were surrounded.”

“They knew about the undead, but the exploding ones we saw must not have been mentioned to either general. Or whoever briefed them thought it wasn’t a concern. Neither one expected them to be underground.”

Zel muttered. Ilvriss pounded the table with a fist.

“Ridiculous! If I find the Drake who thought the undead weren’t a concern—”

“The [Scout] that Hawk found fled the battle before the end, but he saw the undead rising. His conclusion was that the Goblin Lord was far more powerful a [Necromancer] than anyone suspected. Hiding the undead beneath the snow—that’s a tactic Az’kerash used to use in the Second Antinium War.”

Ilvriss and Zel shared a concerned glance. Olesm’s heart beat wildly. The [Scout] that Hawk had found had been on the edges of the battlefield near the end. He’d seen the last charge of Garusa Weatherfur, and heard the horns signaling a full retreat. No one close to the place where Thrissiam Blackwing had made his last stand had survived.

“Hrm. It is not good, no. But we must know how much of the Goblin Lord’s army lives, yes? I know Goblins rebuild their forces quickly. It is essential to find out. Hrr. Are there any who might scout the army?”

Regrika looked around the table at the Council. A few heads shook—the leader of the Adventurer’s Guild, a very old Drake lady that Olesm recognized, spoke up. She was Selys’ grandmother.

“There’s not a Drake or Gnoll adventurer worthy of the name in the city who could do it to my knowledge. Not a City Runner either; Hawk might be able to do it, but he would refuse to go near the Goblin Lord’s army. Quite sensibly, too.”

“There’s a [Scout] in my party, Halrac Everam. He might be able to do it, but I’d hate to risk him as well.”

Ulrien volunteered the information quietly, and the Council members looked at him. The huge Human man was like a reassuring rock, for all he was...Human. Zel shook his head.

“I would hate to have any of our best die trying to scout the Goblin Lord’s army, Regrika.”

“Hrm. True. But are you sure there are no City Runners of renown? I would love to see a list—if the Courier Hawk will not do it, a City Runner might. Courage is needed in dire times, and I would speak to any who might volunteer for such a mission.”

The Gnoll [Champion] seemed insistent, so after a moment one of the Council members fetched a list with names of City Runners in Liscor. Regrika pawed through the list, staring at sketches of faces, names, levels, and then looked up.

“I see the issue. Few with high levels. Are you sure there are no others?”

The Council hesitated. Olesm realized they had overlooked someone and spoke up excitedly.

“What about the door to Celum? There are more adventurers and Runners through there.”

Regrika blinked at him.

“A door? What is this?”

Olesm explained briefly about Erin’s magical door, and the Named Adventurer Gnoll shook her head in amazement. That she was impressed made Olesm proud for Erin. Zel nodded slowly.

“True. I’d overlooked the door, but if it came to a siege, I would hope that Erin would allow us to bring her inside the city. Her door could sustain us in a siege and bring reinforcements if needed—”

“Humans!”

Ilvriss uttered it as a curse and folded his arms. But Olesm had remembered something else about the inn and edged over to Regrika

Blackpaw tentatively.

“There *is* another Runner who might be willing to take the risk, Miss Blackpaw.”

“Oh? Why is she not on the list? Is she Human?”

The Named Adventurer looked intrigued. Olesm nodded eagerly.

“Her name is Ryoka Griffin. She’s quite good—she ran through the High Passes by herself, once! I could introduce you to her perhaps.”

“A Human female? A City Runner? Or...a Courier?”

“Not a Courier, Miss Blackpaw, but she’s probably the closest to it in Liscor or Celum!”

Regrika bared her teeth in a smile.

“I would like to meet such a Human. Yes, thank you Olesm Swifttail.”

Olesm flushed with pride. Jelaqua spoke up as well, coming over while Zel and Ilvriss and Zevara argued about Humans.

“We all stay at the inn. We’d be happy to show you around after this.”

“I would be most honored, yes. And I shall introduce you to my companion too. She is a powerful [Mage], a Gold-rank adventurer. We must drink together, yes?”

“Of course! I’m sure Erin and Ryoka would be honored to meet you!”

Olesm practically fell over himself with pleasure. Another famous guest for Erin’s inn! Wouldn’t she be pleased when Olesm brought a Named Adventurer to her inn?

After a moment Ilvriss called everyone to order. He pointedly tapped on the map with the Goblin Lord’s probable location on it.

“Our business is not concluded. We have more to do. Regardless of whether or not the Goblin Lord attacks, I suspect him to head north. If he does, we must ensure the nearby villages are cleared long before his arrival

and track his movements heading north. Hopefully he becomes the Humans' problem. Either way, we must prepare ourselves."

Ilvriss' eyes glinted as he looked around the room, meeting everyone's gaze but Ulrien and Jelaqua's.

"The Goblin Lord must die."

"The Goblin Lord must die. However, I regret to say that we will most likely be gone before he falls."

Xrn stood in the chamber of the Queen of the Free Antinium and spoke calmly as she held her staff. Three other Antinium stood with her. Tersk of the Armored Antinium, Pivr of the Flying Antinium, still covered in wounds, and Klbkch. The Queen of the Free Antinium looked down at Xrn.

"I see. You will return to the Hives?"

The blue Antinium lowered her head and Klbkch felt an ache in his chest.

"I must. The Grand Queen wishes me to return and fears I may be wounded if the Goblin Lord attacks."

"I see."

Klbkch's Queen shifted her weight. He saw her looking from Prognugator to Prognugator, and then at Pivr's wounded form with some satisfaction. Her only comment was to Xrn, though.

"I trust you have seen what my Hive has produced and seen the worth of it."

"I have."

Tersk stepped forwards and bowed. He was still not wearing his armor. He seemed greatly changed as he addressed both Klbkch and the Queen.

“I have seen much my Queen will see the value of. Much. I will petition her to recognize your Hive formally.”

“I too. The Antinium should not face such a threat below. Not alone.”

Pivr spoke up, sounding subdued. Klbkch glanced at him, surprised. Xrn nodded at both and then spoke up, voice clear as she clicked her mandibles together respectfully.

“We have agreed that your Hive is worthy, Queen of the Free Antinium. To that end, we shall request that a link be set up between Hives. We have magical artifacts that may do so—for now, we must communicate between Listeners.”

Ah, yes. The Antinium created specifically to listen. It was a crude way of communicating at distance and the other Hives all used magical artifacts to speak, rather than Listeners. But the Free Antinium had been cut off for years thanks to their ‘unproven’ status. Klbkch tasted acid. His Queen surely felt the same, but she only inclined her head to Xrn.

“In ages past we linked minds. Now...we cannot. However, I will confer with the other Queens as to what is to be done about this Goblin Lord, gladly.”

“I am pleased, oh Queen of the Free Antinium. I thank you for your hospitality, though we shall linger for a few days more. I wish to...take in this city, and I understand both Tersk and Pivr have their own needs.”

Xrn nodded at Klbkch. He nodded back. They had a few more moments. Time...oh, it was so fleeting. But perhaps this door—Erin’s door—they had talked, Xrn and he. They had made plans for the future. So had his Queen. The Antinium would live. They would restore themselves and return to Rhir. This Goblin Lord wasn’t worth mentioning.

Osthia Blackwing was now convinced that there was no greater threat on the continent than the Goblin Lord. None. Not even the Antinium were

so dangerous. Not because the Goblin Lord himself was that terrifying—he would have lost the battle against her uncle and Garusa normally. No, it was his master that scared Osthia to her core.

Az'kerash, the Necromancer, hovered in the air before the kneeling Goblin Lord in his tent. Osthia, bound and helpless, could only stare up at the projection of the dreaded enemy of the Drakes as his deathless gaze swept the tent.

Black eyes and white pupils. One look from the [Necromancer] sent chills down Osthia's tail. But the man's voice was refined, scholarly.

"I do not see why you need the Drake. Oldblood she may be, but a useful corpse she is not. Unless you intend to keep her for other... diversions?"

There was disapproval in his tone. Osthia shivered in cold fury. She would rather die. But the Goblin Lord hadn't touched her except to interrogate her about his master. The kneeling Goblin shook his head.

"She is spy. Tells me information."

"Information I already have."

Az'kerash's voice was filled with scorn. He gestured at Osthia, and then made a gesture. A map floated in the air in front of Osthia.

"I need no spies, only magic. And I have given you your orders. Go past Liscor. Reclaim the Goblins in the mountain. Tame their leader, build your forces. Wreak havoc among the Human lands and become the Goblin King if you are able. If not, die cursing your weakness."

He stared down at his apprentice, the Goblin Lord. But it seemed to Osthia that Az'kerash was speaking not as a master to a pupil, but a disinterested owner giving instructions to a dog. The Goblin Lord's fate only mildly concerned Az'kerash. It was chaos he craved.

"I have my trusted servants in Liscor. Their tasks must not be compromised. They have been occupied there for a long time, it seems. Gathering information."

Servants? Osthia started. The [Necromancer] had servants? Az'kerash seemed preoccupied, but suddenly the Goblin Lord laughed. Both the Drake and man stared at him.

“What do you find funny?”

“Servants? Not in Liscor long time.”

“Really? I was assured by Ijvani that they had reached the city long past when I inquired.”

The [Necromancer]'s eyes narrowed. The Goblin Lord laughed again, clearly delighting in informing his master of the lie.

“Not true. I met them. A week ago. They were lost. Could not find Liscor.”

“Indeed?”

Az'kerash's brows snapped together. He frowned.

“In that case, it seems I must reprimand my servants. Thank you for telling me.”

Both Osthia and the Goblin Lord took some small pleasure in seeing the irritation on the Necromancer's face. He waved a hand, about to dismiss the spell and then spoke curtly.

“Go north as I have told you, my apprentice. Burn the cities as you pass. Leave strong ones unharmed. And kill the Drake. I do not like loose ends.”

His image vanished. Osthia saw the Goblin Lord stand up, brushing dirt from his knees. He looked at her. And she knew that she would live.

Because if there was anything the Goblin Lord could do to spite the Necromancer, he would. He was Az'kerash's enemy as much as anyone. But Osthia feared...she feared they were all just pawns in some larger game the Necromancer was playing. She just wished she could tell someone what was happening.

Plots and treachery. Intrigue, planning—the minds of the leaders of many sides plotted and thought away across the continent. Each had their own agenda. Each was a fool. For however strong they may be, whatever powers they possessed, what were they?

Merely mortal. Well, Az'kerash might be an exception, but he was still young. Especially by Dragon standards.

In a game of armies and kings, of death and battle, a lone Dragon sat in his cave, aloof from it all. He was mighty. He had lived through the rise and fall of greater empires than any that now existed on the earth. He was a ruler of fire, one of the last and mightiest of his kind. He was a Dragon.

And now he had reached perfection. On the ground of his cavern, the Dragon gently, and with exquisite care, extended a claw. With the finest of control he gently lowered the talon a fraction and tapped a glowing screen.

The iPhone beneath the Dragon blinked for a second, its screen glowing brightly in the dim light. It was surrounded by ice and cooled by powerful freezing spells; it seemed that it had a tendency to overheat and Teriarch couldn't be bothered to keep repairing it with magic.

And the iPhone was especially strained as of now. Teriarch's eyes flicked as he analyzed the small screen and he breathed out. At last. He had done it. He had struggled—so hard! And he had persevered. He had accomplished what no other being in this world had done, he was sure of it.

“Let me see. As of now, I am producing...”

His eyes flickered over the screen. Teriarch counted for a moment, and then took a breath.

“Five hundred thirty-eight quintillion, two hundred fifty-five quadrillion, eight hundred two trillion, nine hundred seventy-one billion, six hundred twenty-one million, three hundred sixty-two thousand, four hundred and eight...excuse me, four hundred and *nine* cookies per second, given of course a lack of any manual input on my part.”

Teriarch proudly stared down at the screen of the iPhone, which was showing a game and a lot of numbers. Cookie Clicker, the app, ran on as Teriarch gently tapped the screen a few times, watching cookies soar across the screen.

He'd done it. He'd clicked the screen, bought many, many upgrades, and finally, become a lord of cookies. Teriarch had no idea what the strange confectionaries actually tasted like, but he was sure they were some sort of granulated sugar treat. He'd had similar substances over the years, even if he'd never had 'chocolate chip' cookies.

And now he was producing so many! Teriarch was at the head of a virtual cookie empire that could literally bury his opponents live in cookies. He had enough cookies to fill the sea, to build himself a castle and army! He could do anything! He was a cookie god!

The Dragon blinked at the tiny screen and then slowly rolled—or perhaps collapsed—onto his side. He stared at the screen.

“I feel so empty.”

4.27 H

[Warrior Level 1!]

[Skill – Basic Footwork obtained!]

[Princess Level 6!]

[Skill – Royal Tax obtained!]

Lyonette woke up. The bright sunlight of dawn was the first thing she saw through the open curtains of her window. She looked around in a sudden panic, remembered that Erin had told her to sleep in today, and relaxed. Then her eyes widened.

“Oh. *Oh!*”

There was a ball of fur sleeping next to her, hogging the blanket. Lyonette gathered up Mrsha in her arms and hugged the Gnoll gently, ignoring Mrsha’s sleepy protests.

“I did it! I did it! Mrsha! I leveled!”

A paw slapped Lyonette in the mouth. Mrsha sagged in Lyonette’s arms, completely limp. Gently, Lyonette put the Gnoll back in her bed and then got up and paced around the room frantically.

“I—it happened at last! *At last!* How? It has to be—Brunkr? But I just did that because—I thought—I never expected—no *wonder* Mavia leveled up then, if that’s what knighting people does! Why didn’t Mother or Father ever say...? But I leveled! And I got a Skill! [Royal Tax]. I’m sure I saw it listed in the secret book of kings Father showed me...”

She paused, gulping for air and feeling dizzy. Lyonette turned around and hesitated. She saw a pile of blankets and a pillow on the other side of the room. Ryoka slept with Lyonette and Mrsha, but she’d already woken up and gone out it seemed.

“I can’t talk to her about it anyways. I could but, it’s dangerous...”

Suddenly, Lyonette drooped. The excitement in her veins faded slightly. She'd done it. She'd finally leveled as a [Princess]. But she couldn't tell anyone that news. She had no one to talk to.

Glumly, Lyonette went downstairs and found the inn was full of visitors already. Erin greeted her as Lyonette mechanically served tables and brought drinks and food out.

"Thanks, Miss Human."

A group of Drakes had just finished their meal. They counted up coins and tossed them onto the table. Lyonette blinked down at the silver and copper coins and called out.

"Wait! You overpaid."

"Did we?"

The Drakes turned. One, with dusky orange scales counted up the coins with a claw.

"Nope, looks good to us."

He and the others left. Lyonette blinked down at the coins. They *had* overpaid, by about three copper coins!

"Ooh, what's this about pay?"

Erin materialized out of the kitchen, bits of fish scales on her hands. She cocked her head as Lyonette showed her the coins.

"There are three extra. I feel bad, because they paid too much—"

"Oh, that's not overpaying, that's a tip!"

"A tip?"

Lyonette bit her lip. Was the extra tip...? Surely not! But she owned nothing on this continent. Why wouldn't her Skill affect her job?

"Here's the extra—"

She tried to give it to Erin, but the [Innkeeper] pushed the coins back into her hand.

"No, it's a tip, Lyonette, a tip! I can't take that! You keep it and add it to your salary—which I am paying you, now."

“Okay.”

The [Princess] went back to busing tables, noting that Ishkr got nothing like a tip. However, the next three tables all gave her tips, usually one or two copper coins at most. They didn’t blink at giving her the tip, although Lyonette pointed out the extra money. Nor did anyone comment on the extra money either. It was unconscious, the way they added up coins and gave her a tiny bit extra. A royal tax indeed.

Lyonette wished she could tell Erin. But that would put the girl in danger, wouldn’t it? All she could do was helplessly feed Apista, and then take a short break to rest her head in her hands in her room upstairs.

Mrsha was up by now, but she was busy having breakfast at a table downstairs. Lyonette sat in her room and heard a *thump*. She looked up and saw an Antinium Worker pause in her doorway. He was holding a very long length of wood in one hand. Above, she could hear hammering and many bodies shuffling about.

The Antinium were still working on a third floor and a new wing to the inn. Lyonette sighed and stood up as more Workers filed past her with wood, roof tiles, and buckets of copper nails.

No one knew she was a [Princess]. That secret she had kept, out of fear for what might happen and more recently, shame. No one on this continent knew Lyonette’s true identity, save for Magnolia Reinhart herself. No one knew Lyonette was royalty.

That was how it had to be. Lyonette told herself that as she went downstairs with a smile, to play with Mrsha and help Ishkr with the crowds. It was safer this way. Her identity was a danger to the people she had grown to love. So she had to keep the secret. Lyonette had told no one who she was, and no one would ever know a [Princess] worked in the Wandering Inn.

Okay, Pawn knew. And Ryoka. And...yes, Magnolia Reinhart and whomever she’d told. But that was hardly anyone! Besides that, no one knew.

No one at all.

“Yeah, she’s definitely a princess. I’m one hundred percent sure. Two hundred percent.”

Ryoka picked at the sliced raw meat Krshia had offered her in a bowl and wondered if it was full of E.coli or some other native bacteria to this world. She wondered if there were some tactful way to refuse eating it. She sighed, pushed the bowl back, and sat back on her side of the couch.

Krshia blinked at her. She and Brunkr were sitting in the Gnoll [Shopkeeper]’s apartment. Their ears were twitching, a sure sign of agitation. Ryoka scowled at them.

“What? Don’t tell me you didn’t figure it out? It was obvious! I’d expect Erin not to pick up on the clues, but you two? Lyonette talks and acts like she’s been raised in a rich household! She thinks you need a separate fork for salad!”

The Gnolls shifted. Brunkr looked at Krshia, and his aunt shrugged helplessly.

“We did not speak to Lyonette so much as witness her actions, Ryoka Griffin. They were that of a thief, and her speech and etiquette were not displayed to us. However, what Brunkr heard and his new class—”

“A [Knight]. I am a [Knight].”

Brunkr stared in shock at his paws. Ryoka sighed.

“You woke up and got the class. But you *knew* you’d get it, because you heard Lyonette knighting you, right?”

The male Gnoll nodded.

“Ishkr did too. But I could not believe—a [Princess]? Truly?”

Maybe it was part of the culture in this world. Ryoka watched as the Gnolls exchanged wide-eyed looks. In her world, on earth, meeting royalty was still a big deal for a lot of people, but it wasn’t unheard of. People with royal blood were people too; a lot of the mystique around them had vanished over the years. Whereas in this world princesses were, well, [Princesses].

“It doesn’t change much.”

Krshia frowned.

“But it does. Her actions change when viewed as that of a [Princess]. Harming her would be a grave mistake, yes? As for her importance...”

“She can make people into [Knights]. And she can serve beer. I don’t see what else makes her special.”

Ryoka sighed. She could tell this might lead to something in the future and she was already not enjoying the thought of it. She shifted in her seat.

“Okay, Lyonette’s royalty. It’s big. Don’t tell anyone, although I bet all the Gnolls know about it already. But isn’t there a more important person in Liscor right now? Who’s this Regrika Blackpaw?”

The name made both Krshia and Brunkr sit up proudly. The female Gnoll smiled at Ryoka.

“She is a hero. A legend. I know not why she has come to Liscor if that is what you are asking. She is not of our tribe and we have not had the opportunity to speak with her. But it is enough that she is here, and her motives are her own, yes?”

“You seem excited to meet her. She’s a big deal?”

“A Named Adventurer is famous. A legend. How can we not look up to someone who has accomplished so much? We Gnolls crave such figures as all people do. It is an honor to meet her.”

Ryoka nodded. She could understand that. Regrika Blackpaw was like a sports star, a celebrity, a national hero. She saw Brunkr stand up and flex his arms and then pace around both couches, unable to sit still. He no longer wore a bandage on his right arm; it had completely healed. Now the Gnoll seemed to vibrate with energy and excitement.

“It is times like this that makes me glad I was born, yes? My dream is in me. I have my arm, and debts to pay. I will be a [Knight] worthy of my class! And strong. It is good honored Blackpaw came here. It tells me to look up to the sky and dream of what I could be.”

He turned to Ryoka, eyes shining. She saw a smile on his face—a somewhat scary sight given the sharp canine teeth Gnolls had. But she had

to smile back. Ryoka glanced around, eyed the bowl of raw meat, and then nodded to the door.

“Yeah. What we can be. I’d love to stay Krshia, Brunkr, but I have a date with the wind and snow. I’ll uh, see you around.”

She had intended to make this a quick visit, but Krshia’s paw shot out and pushed Ryoka back into her seat. The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] looked shocked as she shook her head.

“You have not touched your food yet. We could not let you go without hospitality, especially not to one who is a friend to our clan.”

“What? Aw, no. I’m really—”

“I insist. Eat. And then we must celebrate Brunkr’s new class, yes? We shall feast, and invite Erin. Or perhaps have our celebration at her inn! You will come as an honored guest.”

There was no getting out of it. Ryoka found the bowl of chopped meat pressed into her hands. She grinned weakly and cursed herself for not jumping out the window when she had a chance. Oh well.

At least Ivolethe would like the food.

“Gnolls.”

Someone said the word. The four members of the Horns of Hammerad looked up to see who said it, and then down. No one in their party had said it—it was a group of Humans sitting a few tables away.

Other adventurers. They looked as dispirited as the Horns of Hammerad. As any other adventurer in the room, really. They were sitting in the Adventurer’s Guild. And today, no one was feeling too energetic. No one except the Gnolls, that was.

They were out in force today, taking requests, chatting, tails wagging, standing tall. The other adventurers, Drakes, Humans, and the other races

like half-Elves, sat and didn't meet anyone's eyes. The reason was simple: they'd gotten a glimpse of Regrika Blackpaw and been crushed.

Not physically. The Gnoll wasn't walking around smacking people with her paws or her greatsword, although if she was, who could stop her? No, it was a mental attack. The Named Adventurer probably hadn't even realized she was doing it. But she'd effectively crushed the spirits of all the adventurers in the city just by walking down the street.

Ceria Springwalker sat at a table and felt like one of the little beetles coming out from a rotting floorboard at the table. She felt like one of them, especially when Ksmvr surreptitiously bent down and crunched one between his mandibles. She felt like a little beetle after seeing a Named Adventurer in the flesh.

Again.

The half-Elf could remember when she'd met Gazi the Omniscient. The feeling was similar. It wasn't just the presence such people exuded, it was knowing all the things they'd accomplished and then measuring yourself against them.

It made you feel *small*.

As she sat, Ceria fingered the wand that Ryoka had brought back from Invrisil for her. A wand, some magic robes, and a burned spellbook...what else did she have? Nothing. Her magic was a tiny snowflake in the wind compared to real adventurers.

"They look happy."

This time someone at their table spoke. Ceria didn't look up; she could hear Pisces' voice. She nodded, staring at another beetle.

"The Gnolls? Why shouldn't they be? She's *their* hero. A Named Adventurer from your species walks in, and of course you're happy."

"Right."

Someone else spoke. Yvlon.

"What's her title? I mean, her nickname. Don't all Named Adventurers get one?"

"Regrika the Fortress. I think."

A pause.

“Not very original.”

“Try saying that to her face. I—oh, wait, that’s not it. I got it mixed up. She’s nicknamed ‘Fortress Blackpaw’. Because no one can lay a scratch on her.”

Ceria sighed and looked up as a pair of Antinium fingers picked up another beetle. She saw Ksmvr freeze as he lifted the squirming insect up. Of all the adventurers, he looked the least concerned.

“Pardon me Captain Ceria. Is eating bugs off the floor not permitted? Should I pay for my consumption?”

“I think they’ll pay you if you eat enough, Ksmvr. Aren’t you... bothered by seeing a Named Adventurer?”

The Antinium considered the question.

“I am not sure. What emotions should her visage produce in me?”

“Oh, I don’t know. Hopelessness, despair. A sensation that you’ll never reach that level no matter how hard you try and that your entire life has been wasted because you can’t imagine yourself ever becoming that famous or successful?”

Ceria slumped over the table and saw Pisces and Yvlon wince. Ksmvr paused.

“No, I do not believe so. I will inform you if such emotions cross my mind. Are they to be desired?”

Hollow laughter was his response. The Horns of Hammerad sat. They did feel small. Small and unworthy. They only looked up when someone called their name.

“Hey! You lot! Come over and stop moping about!”

A female Drake with light green scales was waving at them from the receptionist’s desk. The Horns got up and slowly trudged over to Selys. She regarded them critically.

“You look terrible. What, is just seeing a Named Adventurer enough to make you all act like invalids?”

Pisces raised a hand.

“I am, in fact, nursing a hangover as well, Miss Selys. So if you could lower your voice?”

He rubbed at his haggard face as both Yvlon and Ceria glared at him. Selys sighed.

“I don’t know why Erin puts up with you, I really don’t. Okay, time to do my job. I’ve talked with my grandm—the Guildmaster. I’m sorry, but you’re not certified Gold-rank adventurers yet. You’ll have to take on a few requests and prove you can handle yourselves before you get the new rank.”

She looked sympathetic as all the Horns of Hammerad groaned. Ceria felt a weight settle on her back. She knew it was unlikely, but she’d hoped they could become Gold-rank adventurers. But new armor and weapons did not a Gold-rank adventurer make.

“Told you we should have tried it at the guild in Celum.”

Pisces grumbled. Yvlon shook her head.

“That would be...awkward. At least we know where we stand. Is that all, Selys?”

“No. Actually, I’ve got more bad news for you. Or rather, Pisces.”

Selys sighed as she leaned over the counter. Pisces frowned.

“What about? Ah. Don’t tell me. My class has once again stigmatized me in the eyes of your Guild.”

“Don’t be so dramatic! It’s not like that—”

Pisces crossed his arms, frowning. Selys hesitated.

“Okay, maybe it’s because you’re a [Necromancer]. Word’s spread and people like my grandmother, the Guildmaster, are a bit...unhappy.”

That was surprising and unwelcome news. Pisces scowled. Suddenly concerned, Ceria put her hands on the desk.

“Hold on, I thought no one had an issue with Pisces being a [Necromancer]. He wasn’t when we reformed the Horns of Hammerad.”

“Yeah, well, he wasn’t an adventurer until recently. And with all this news about the Goblin Lord and his undead army...”

“I should have known. It seems my magic is unwelcome wherever I go.”

Already Pisces was withdrawing, growing more hostile by the moment. Ceria turned to him and held up a hand. He subsided briefly, looking angry. She remembered that look from Wistram and turned desperately to Selys.

“I know Pisces’ magic is a touchy subject around here, what with the Necromancer, but he hasn’t done anything wr—okay, he hasn’t done *much* wrong.”

“I know, I know!”

Selys looked frustrated. She tapped a claw on the counter.

“Look, we’re not kicking him out. And we’re not saying he can’t practice necromancy. He just can’t animate, uh, people.”

“What? But that’s—”

“It’s the rules. I’m sorry. If we see him raising dead bodies—no matter what the reason—he’ll be arrested. Or worse.”

“So I am prevented from my craft. How wonderfully tolerant.”

Pisces sneered. Selys gave him a look.

“I’m just relaying orders, Mister Necromancer. While you’re in Liscor or around the city, you can’t use the corpses of people.”

“Of any species?”

“Funny you should mention that. I have a list. Let’s see...no using Drake corpses, Drake bones, Gnoll corpses or bones, the remains of Humans, Minotaurs, Centaurs, half-Elves, Dwarves, Drowned Women—or Men—the parts of Stitch People, any aspect of a Dullahan...not sure if they have bones, so that’s why the wording’s so...anyways, no Gazer bodies either...”

Selys ran down a very long list of what was probably every major known species in the world. She had to take a few deep breaths when she’d finished. Pisces was looking even more irate now, but Ceria had noticed an omission in the Drake’s list of undeadables.

“You didn’t have Lizardfolk on that list. Is that a mistake?”

“Oh, no. The city’s fine with using their bodies, if you find them.”

“How *lenient*.”

Pisces was clearly agitated. Ceria traded glances with Yvlon. On one hand she understood the city’s desire for undead to be kept off the streets. On the other hand, a blanket ban against all undead was...reasonable. But Pisces was part of their group. She hesitated, unsure of what to say.

Other adventurers were staring at their group, and most were eying Pisces with no small deal of hostility. The [Necromancer]’s shoulders were hunched. He was clearly aware of the staring and he seemed ready to snap. Ceria opened her mouth, unsure if she could defend him, when someone else leaned on the table.

Ksmvr. He cleared his throat and gently snapped his mandibles together.

“Miss Shivertail, may I state my objections to your restrictions on my fellow teammate?”

Selys blinked at the Antinium and eyed him for a moment.

“Uh, okay. What’s the problem?”

Ksmvr nodded. Oblivious to the stares, he raised his voice and spoke calmly.

“I feel that this restriction on the summoning of undead is unjust. You are restricting our tactical diversity with such actions. The raising of the dead is a key facet to the [Necromancer] class, and I for one object to the crippling of one of my fellow adventurer’s abilities. I am sure my colleagues feel the same.”

He nodded around the room at the shocked Drakes, Humans and Gnolls. There was a pause and one of the Drakes, a short fellow with black scales stood up.

“Not I! I’m glad I don’t have to deal with a [Necromancer], let alone journey with one! Who knows if he’d turn me into a zombie after I died! Would you like that, Antinium?”

There was a great deal of hostility in his voice, which Ksmvr seemed to completely ignore. The Antinium nodded calmly.

“I would be insulted if he did not use my body.”

The black-scaled Drake paused.

“What? Are you insane? Why would you want that?”

Ksmvr clicked his mandibles together.

“Animating a fallen teammate’s corpse is the *only* sound tactical decision to be made in a combat situation. Or would you prefer to let your comrades lie where they fall?”

Ceria found herself edging away from the Antinium a bit as he turned and spoke. She and Yvlon were biting their lips. Pisces was staring.

Selys coughed gingerly.

“That’s uh—not what we want, Ksmvr. In fact, that’s sort of why Pisces isn’t allowed to animate the dead in the first place. No one wants to end up as a zombie or ghoul.”

The Antinium turned, looking somewhat irate.

“But that makes no sense. I object most strongly to this rule. Are you implying that my corpse has no tactical value in combat?”

He leaned over the counter, addressing Selys directly.

“I can assure you that my deceased form is quite operable in many situations so long as it has not been dissected, disintegrated, incinerated, consumed, possessed, liquefied, or—”

“Alright, thank you Selys! We’ll be going now. Come on, Ksmvr.”

Ceria dragged Ksmvr back. She desperately signaled to Yvlon, and the female warrior helped Ceria pull the Antinium to the door. Ksmvr was still trying to lecture everyone on the benefits of his corpse as a tool of utility. Pisces was trying not to laugh, and everyone was staring.

They made it out the door and it slammed shut behind them. In the snowy street, Ceria looked around. Yvlon met her eyes, and then both heard a grunting sound. They looked and saw Pisces, trying not to guffaw. Ksmvr looked at him, and then at Ceria.

“Is Comrade Pisces alright, Captain?”

“Fine.”

Ceria sighed. She wanted to cover her face with her hands and get drunk. But she couldn't. Instead, she pointed.

"Let's go back to the inn."

This was her team. Her terrible, mismatched, insane...team. She saw Yvlon smiling for a second as Pisces nearly choked on his robes and then how she caught herself and frowned at the [Necromancer].

Her team. Some days Ceria wondered if they were really a team, or if they would break apart. They were so fragile. Like glass. And they were so, so...*weak*.

Later that day, around lunch, Ceria was sitting at a table eating and reading from her burnt spellbook when she looked up suddenly and shouted.

"I did it!"

Heads turned. The Horns of Hammerad were in the inn along with Ryoka and the Gold-rank adventuring teams. They were having a day off, and Ryoka had come by to tell Erin the Gnolls were having a huge party in her inn later that day.

"You did what?"

Pisces raised his head up. He had been drinking again. It seemed like he was determined to enjoy Erin's hospitality as much as he could, and he was having a second plate of pasta. Ksmvr, determined to copy Pisces, was doing the same, happily scarfing down gluten thanks to his enchanted amulet.

"I did it, Pisces. I learned the spell."

Ceria sat back, her mind buzzing, staring in shock at the slightly burnt pages of the spellbook in front of her. And in her head was something else as well.

Knowledge. A...certainty. A revelation, the sense of a puzzle finally clicking into place. Certainty, in an uncertain world.

Magic.

“[Ice Wall].”

Ceria breathed the words. A sheet of ice rose in front of her table, cutting off Pisces’ robes and freezing them in place. It was a thin wall, but it *was* a wall, and as Pisces yelped and tried to free himself, Ceria felt the magic surging in her. She looked around and saw people staring.

“Ice magic!”

Jelaqua sat up, chortling and pointing. Erin rushed out of the kitchen and exclaimed when she saw the six foot high barrier of ice. It was cold enough that it wasn’t melting yet, despite the warm room.

“Oh! Wow! It’s that spell you told me about! The one your old master knew how to use! Did you learn how to do it just now Ceria? That’s *amazing!*”

“Amazing and *cold!* Free my leg, Springwalker!”

Pisces howled at Ceria and blew hot flames onto the barrier of ice before she could dispel the magic. The ice melted onto Pisces’ robes, drenching the young man. Ceria watched as Ksmvr helped kick the ice wall apart, grinning stupidly.

“It’s not as strong as some examples of the spell I’ve seen, but for a first time attempt it’s quite reasonable. Yes indeed, I am quite impressed.”

Typhenous smiled as he leaned forwards, hands on his staff. Jelaqua pounded the table.

“Hah! A [Mage] learning a spell’s another reason for a party!”

“Wait, so you just learned it?”

Erin looked at Ceria. The half-Elf smiled.

“I just did. Remember that spell I was working on? The one that that mage—Teriarch—showed me? It was [Ice Wall]. I knew how the spell worked and Illphres was beginning to teach me it but—”

There were tears around the edges of her eyes. The half-Elf wiped at them, feeling mystified and relieved at once. Pisces stopped brushing at the water on his robes and glanced up at Ceria. She looked at him and felt the past drawing at her.

“Ah.”

That was all he said. He eyed the wall of ice, half melted and broken in places and tapped it.

“Half a foot thick. As Typhenous has said, a quite passable first attempt. Useful in a myriad of situations I would imagine.”

“Yeah.”

Ceria grinned, still brushing at her eyes. She felt Erin hovering around her back.

“It’s—it’s great. I’ve wondered if I could master it, but I figured it out so quickly—”

“A Tier 4 spell. Worthy of any Gold-rank mage, wouldn’t you say?”

“Oh yes. Not my forte, but I know similar spells and have made use of them on many occasions.”

Typhenous came over. He nodded to Ceria, a smile on his face. Ceria was accepting his compliments, and Moore’s, when the door opened.

“Yvlon!”

The armored women came in, brushing snow off of her new armor. She had the enchanted sword and buckler at her side. When she saw the wall of ice she halted.

“What’s this?”

“A wall of ice. I just learned how to cast it.”

Yvlon stared as Ceria explained in brief. The human woman nodded brusquely.

“Good. Just in time. I’ve got a request for us at last. It’s just past Esthelm.”

“What?”

Ceria sat up as Ksmvr and Pisces both looked up from their position around the fireplace. The half-Elf frowned at Yvlon and opened her mouth. Yvlon looked grim, and a bit upset, although Ceria couldn't have said exactly why.

Erin looked from Ceria to Yvlon with a slight frown on her face.

"You're going on a request? Fighting? I mean, you're going to hunt monsters and stuff?"

"So it seems. We talked, but I didn't—"

Ceria realized the other adventurers were looking and coughed.

"Good job, Yvlon. What's the request?"

"Bears. There's three of them that have been bothering the people of Esthelm. Scaring [Hunters], going after people in their homes—it's not worth much, but someone needs to get rid of them before they kill someone."

The other people in the inn clustered around Yvlon as she explained. Apparently the cave had already been found and it wasn't far. The request was a simple extermination one. The only catch was that the bears were all adult. And male.

Ryoka frowned. She was sitting at a table as Ceria, Pisces, and Yvlon sat around the table. Ksmvr had gone into Liscor to find them a transport.

"I was under the impression that bears—especially *male* bears—hunted alone. Wouldn't they kill each other rather than work together?"

Ceria shook her head. She was pondering over a map of the region and trying to eye Yvlon while she spoke. The other woman was ignoring her looks.

"When times get tough, even bears will work together to bring down big monsters. It's a tough world."

"Sounds like a simple mission. Better watch out, though."

Halrac came over. The [Scout] didn't speak much, but apparently he was familiar with this sort of request. He nodded at Ceria.

“Make sure they’re not Mothbears. It’s hard to imagine a [Hunter] mistaking one for the other, but it can happen. Also check to make sure they’re not rabid.”

Jelaqua nodded.

“Or infected with Brainshrooms! We had to fight through half a forest’s worth of animals controlled by fungi one time. Not fun! I got one on my head and I had to get rid of my body before the mushrooms got me!”

“We’ll do that. I guess we’ll see what happens.”

Ceria mumbled as she looked from Pisces to Yvlon. He was frowning and Yvlon wasn’t staring at either of her teammates. Both adventurers looked concerned, for different reasons. Ceria was too. But she forced a smile for the sake of the others.

“I guess we’ll see. It’s just bears. How hard—”

She paused as Erin and Ryoka winced. Ceria gulped and sighed.

“We’d better get moving.”

“So, why did you decide to take the request, Yvlon? Without asking us?”

Ceria tried to keep her voice neutral as she covered herself with a cloak. She was sitting in a wagon as it bumped along the frozen ground. Pisces and Ksmvr both looked up from their seats at Yvlon. The armored woman glanced up at Ceria and shrugged.

“I got tired of sitting around. I’m as healed as—well, I’m better now, and we’ve got all these new artifacts. We want to be Gold-rank adventurers, right? We might as well start taking requests.”

“To hunt bears. Hardly an illustrious task, or so I feel.”

Pisces frowned. Yvlon glanced at him, and then away. Her regard for Pisces’ opinion couldn’t have been more plain. Ceria saw Pisces’ face harden and spoke up.

“That’s not what I mind. It’s just that we normally talk things over first.”

“We agreed Esthelm was a good place to look for contracts, especially since there’s not much work around Liscor or Celum.”

“Yeah, but—you know what? Never mind.”

Ceria sat back in the wagon. She wondered if this was how Calruz had felt when he was leading the Horns of Hammerad. He’d had to deal with annoying members of his group she recalled. People with strong opinions who made their own decisions. She’d caused him to lose his temper several times while they’d journeyed together.

“Still, I guess I was hoping our first contract would be bigger.”

Yvlon looked up and at Ceria. She shrugged.

“A Silver-rank team would have to prepare for a request like that. You think bears are easy to kill? I bet even someone like Halrac’d set a few traps before trying to bother them in their den.”

“True. I guess I’m too used to hanging around him and the other Gold-rank adventurers to think clearly.”

Ceria sighed.

“After seeing Regrika Blackpaw as well...I bet she’ll enter Liscor’s dungeon tomorrow, or maybe today. I can’t imagine she’d fear many traps and she has that Gold-rank mage with her. Did you see him? I could tell he was a powerful [Mage] across the street. The quests they normally take on...it’s humbling to think about.”

Yvlon grunted, which could have been an acknowledgement.

“Makes you wonder if we’ll ever hit Level 30, let alone Level 40 or higher. You just learned...[Ice Wall]? Is that a really high level spell?”

“No. Yes. It’s one that grows with the [Mage]. My master could make walls of ice several feet thick. I can barely manage a foot if I concentrate.”

Ceria sighed. She’d learned one spell. And while the rush of exhilaration still hadn’t left her, she knew that was one spell compared to the many Illphres had known. And her former master had still died. Put like that, she felt just as bad as she had that morning.

“We’re still Silver-rank. Even with all these artifacts. I thought we should remember that, and chose a request for us to learn our limits.”

The armored woman tapped her sword and the enchanted buckler which could create a force shield. Ceria nodded, but Pisces sat up, suddenly frowning.

“Silver-rank? I would tend to disagree with that assessment, Miss Byres. I consider our collective skillset to be equivalent to a new Gold-rank team. I certainly rate my own prowess at such a level.”

There was a snap in Pisces’ voice that made Ceria wince. He’d been angry all day and it was coming out now, possibly at the worst of times. They were all sitting on a wagon in the cold, and without space, it meant that he was too close to Yvlon to separate.

And Yvlon wasn’t being diplomatic today at all. She raised her eyebrows skeptically.

“Oh? You think you’re on the level of Halrac, or Typhenous?”

“Of course not.”

Pisces raised his nose and sniffed archly at her.

“Your flawed comparison refers to two veteran Gold-rank adventurers, who occupy a position at the higher end of the simplistic ranking system adventurers employ. However, I know my strengths. I am the highest-level individual in this association, whether in my main class or collectively. My Skills and spells have both been of invaluable service to the party, yet I am crippled by these restrictions placed upon my class.”

“Sensible ones, I’d imagine. No one wants their friend or family to become undead.”

“I hardly go around animating corpses of the recently deceased.”

“No, but some people remember Az’kerash and the havoc he caused. Or are you saying [Necromancers] are all different and that they don’t let their creations prey on the innocent?”

Yvlon sat up, eyes flashing. Ceria opened her mouth, but couldn’t find the words to interject in time. Pisces drew himself together and spoke gravely.

“I know what Az’kerash did. I do not endorse his beliefs or defend his crimes against the continents of Izril or Terandria. However, as a fellow [Necromancer], I admire what he has achieved. Is that so hard to grasp?”

“It is to me. Admiring anything about the undead. About *zombies*—”

The party was breaking down in front of her eyes. Ceria opened her mouth and saw Ksmvr sitting up, looking from Yvlon to Pisces with apparent concern. Pisces spoke, hunching in on himself, defensive, the same look in his eyes as when he’d been exiled by Wistram’s Council of Mages.

“Ah, so we come to it at last. I have noted your disdain for my profession and my school of magic, Yvlon Byres. Let us not bandy words. You hate me and what I do. Why conceal the truth? You would hardly be the first or last to feel this way.”

He glared at Yvlon, daring her to say it. And when she did, Ceria was sure, Pisces would disappear. Yvlon’s gaze burned. She took a deep breath, opened her mouth, and—paused. She stared at Pisces and then to the surprise of everyone, shook her head.

“I don’t hate you.”

“What?”

Pisces’ eyes widened. Yvlon sighed.

“I don’t hate you, Pisces. I think you’re annoying, obnoxious at times, and certainly rude. But I don’t hate you.”

That was the last thing Ceria had expected to hear. Yvlon went on.

“I hate necromancy. I hate the undead. You—you wouldn’t be my first dining partner or choice for a teammate, but you I can live with.”

“But necromancy is both my class and specialization as a [Mage]. How do you reconcile that knowledge?”

Pisces studied Yvlon intently, but without the guarded hostility he’d had a moment ago. Yvlon hesitated. She looked at him and then at Ceria. The half-Elf held her breath.

“I—”

“Hey you lot! We’re here!”

All the adventurers jumped. They looked up and saw the man driving the wagon they were sitting on looking back at them. Termin the [Wagon Driver] waved his hand and they saw Esthelm’s walls staring at them. They’d been so engrossed in their conversation that none of the Horns of Hammerad had noticed the city.

“Having a fine argument, were you?”

Termin grinned as they all dismounted the wagon. He was bundled up and stroking the back of one of his horses. He nodded to the city.

“There y’are. You’re looking for a cave, right?”

“That’s right. We’re only a few miles away. I don’t think there’s a road headed that way, so we’ll have to march through the snow to get there.”

Pisces grumbled under his breath, but quietly. He was wearing only his robes despite the freezing cold. He, Yvlon, Ksmvr, and Ceria had all had Erin’s special Corusdeer soup and were feeling warm despite the cold wind.

Termin sighed as he looked at him.

“You lot make me feel cold looking at you. I’d offer to stay around to give you a ride back, but...”

“We wouldn’t ask you to do that. Unless you’re planning on making a delivery from Esthelm to Liscor?”

Ceria looked at Termin. He shook his head and pointed down the road past Esthelm.

“I’m headin’ north as fast as I can. If there’s a Goblin Lord coming, I’d rather be closer to Invril than not. You adventurers take care of yourselves now. If fortune smiles, we’ll meet again one day.”

They bade him farewell and turned past the city. Ceria got a map out and conferred with the others before beginning to march through the deep snow. They moved in silence for a while. Everyone was wondering what Yvlon had meant to say. No one brought it up. After an hour or two of walking, they reached the cave.

“Look. Bear tracks.”

“That’s just snow fallen from the cave’s roof.”

“Oh. Are those bear tracks?”

“Nah, that’s...well, it might be. How should I know?”

“*You’re* the half-Elf.”

“So? That’s speciesism right there, Yvlon. You Humans think we half-Elves know everything about the wilderness just because we live closer to it. It’s all just snow to me.”

“I see fur by the entrance, Comrade Yvlon, Captain Ceria.”

“...That’s probably a good sign, Ksmvr. Does the fur tell you how many bears are inside?”

“The report said three.”

“The report was made by a [Hunter] who didn’t get within a hundred meters of the cave. We could be looking at only one very active bear. Or three.”

“Or six.”

“*Six?* Dead gods, Pisces, don’t joke!”

“It is a legitimate concern, Yvlon. If we are uncertain of our chances, we should take precautions. What do you think, Springwalker?”

“Well...I was thinking we could...”

“Yes? Develop a defensive wall of ice perhaps while Ksmvr takes up his bow and a superior vantage point? With my invisibility spell I could attack from the flanks while Yvlon engages them with her enchanted equipment. If I calculate the odds, I would assume—”

“Calculate? Odds? No, I was just thinking we’d charge in there and sort things out.”

“...”

“...Ceria?”

“What? That’s how Calruz did things. Okay, maybe he had a bit of a plan—”

“I will volunteer to be the first to charge in, Captain Ceria. You may assume from my cries for help or of encouragement whether the danger is —”

“Shush, Ksmvr. Okay, let’s just...go in. I don’t think using an invisibility spell would help in scouting, Pisces. Bears have a good sense of smell.”

“Agreed. I would not risk myself. Very well, but what about scaring the bears out with one of the devices we’ve received? That screaming monster lure?”

“Eh. I thought close quarters would be better, actually. Hear me out. I can freeze part of the cave and make it so only one person gets through. Yvlon uses her shield and pokes the bear with her sword—”

“Pokes?”

“You know. Do your warrior thing. I’m not an expert! She pokes, Pisces and I throw spells and keep the ice barriers up, and Ksmvr shoots at the bear and takes over if Yvlon needs to fall back.”

“One at a time. I like it. We box them in. I also have the enchanted ring with the [Shatterbolt] spell embedded in it—”

“Is that what it’s called? Just don’t hit us. Use it only if you have a clear shot. Okay, let’s do this. Yvlon in front, then Ksmvr and me, and Pisces at the rear.”

“Agreed.”

“Got it.”

“Please use my corpse as a tool if I should fall in battle, Comrade Pisces —”

Perhaps there were better ways to enter the cave, but at least the Horns of Hammerad moved in formation and no one was screaming. The cave system was fairly high overhead and wide enough for them to move all shoulder to shoulder if they chose. It was dark, and uncomfortably silent.

The Horns of Hammerad moved as quietly as possible, hearing Yvlon's armor shift quietly, Pisces' robes brush against the floor, but nothing else.

They found the first bear halfway in. Yvlon knelt by the yellowed skull while Ksmvr kept a lookout with his bow.

"Looks fresh. And whatever ate the bear has sharp teeth. See the bite marks?"

"Cannibalism? The other bears turned on it?"

Ceria whispered. Pisces grunted as he knelt by the skull and shook his head.

"Too small for a bear. These aren't teeth marks either. It looks like the flesh was...clawed from the bone."

"You're sure?"

"I *am* a [Necromancer]."

"What the hell are we looking at, then?"

They got their answer when they found the second bear's skeleton. This one was only half-eaten. Ceria blanched as she saw the lower half, still partly intact.

"Dead gods."

"Something's feasting on it. This bear's huge!"

Yvlon eyed the dark cavern ahead of them. Their only source of light were the [Light] spells both Ceria and Pisces had cast. Pisces wrinkled his nose at the smell of the dead bear's flesh, but he still bent and even touched the half-frozen meat.

"Uh oh."

Ceria could count the number of times Pisces had said that on one hand. She gripped the new wand in her hand tightly.

"What?"

Pisces looked up and around. He conjured another sphere of light into his hands and threw it deeper into the cave. The light illuminated a dark shape. The third bear. It was dead. And crawling on it, slowly carving away

at the bear's body were gelatinous shapes. Their innards glowed as the light passed by them and they slowly turned.

It was Ksmvr who said the word as he dropped his bow and drew both his shortwords.

“Crelers.”

“Back, back!”

Ceria hissed at Pisces. The [Necromancer] cancelled the light spell and the Horns of Hammerad tried to back up. Too late. The Crelers had noticed the light and movement and their fleshy larval forms were turning themselves inside-out, revealing sharp claws, too many sets of teeth—the first leapt towards Ceria as she shouted.

“Get back! [Ice Wall]!”

The Creler crashed into the sheet of ice, biting and tearing at it with pincers and claws sharp enough to cut through steel. Pisces threw a ball of fire and drew his rapier as Yvlon raised her shield.

“Get behind me! Ceria! Seal off the tunnel!”

“I’m trying, but there are too many gaps!”

Ceria pointed and another wall of ice rose, covering part of the cave. But her mastery of the spell was only good enough to raise a wall eight feet high. Tall enough to block a bear, but not Crelers. They swarmed around the wall.

“[Ice Spike]!”

“[Lightning Jolt], [Flame Rapier]! Springwalker, get back!”

Pisces thrust Ceria back and disappeared in a blur. He stabbed through one of the Crelers as it leapt, catching it in a fleshy portion of its body. The skewered Creler *screeched* as Pisces’ flaming rapier impaled it, but it kept moving, trying to climb up the length of the blade and reach Pisces.

“Come. Die.”

Ksmvr was slashing at the Crelers as they swarmed around him, biting at his legs and three arms. Yvlon was cursing. The helmet she was wearing and her plate armor were keeping the Crelers at bay, but they were covering

her. She tossed them to one side and split one of the jointed creatures with a slash of her blade. The enchanted sword cut through the Creler's body with ease.

She was the only one having an easy time of it. Ceria aimed her [Ice Spike] spell and skewered a Creler, and missed another.

"I hate these things so much!"

"Get back! Retreat! Let Yvlon cut them down! Ksmvr!"

Pisces was shouting as a Creler buried itself onto Ksmvr's shoulder and began to bite into the Antinium. Ksmvr tore the Creler off and tried to stomp it to death; it began trying to eat his foot.

"We took out a nest once! We can do it again! Get back! [Ice Wall]!"

This time the wall was low and wide, more of four foot-high barricade than anything else. It covered the cavern and Ceria saw Pisces leap over it, followed by Ksmvr. The Crelers followed, but they had to jump to get over, making them easy targets.

"Yvlon!"

The woman was slashing, cutting the baby Crelers to bits. Her force shield was shimmering in the air as it repelled Crelers leaping at her. She turned, froze.

"*Adult!*"

"What?"

Ceria's blood ran cold. She saw something shoot out of the darkness of the cave, a huge, scuttling form four feet high and twice as long. It barreled into Yvlon and sent the armored woman crashing to the ground.

It looked like some kind of monstrous pill bug with too many legs, tearing claws, and a glowing, fleshy, transparent underbelly where its organs hung, throbbing slightly. The rest of the Creler was biting jaws, claws, all of which lashed Yvlon as she tried to fight it off. But it must have weighed almost as much as a bear, and it was hammering at her breastplate.

And leaving marks. The enchanted metal could withstand the hammer blows, but the Creler's main jaws opened—horizontally, two smaller maws

opening and revealing spitting, gaping mouths, and bit onto Yvlon's sword arm.

She cried out and Ceria saw her enchanted gauntlets begin to *bend* under the crushing strength. She raised her hand.

"[Ice Spike]!"

Three spikes of ice shot from her fingers, each one a pointed javelin. They all broke on the Creler's back, doing no damage.

"*Yvlon!* Someone help her!"

"I will—"

Ksmvr leapt up, impossibly high thanks to his Ring of Jumping and then kicked himself off a wall. He smashed onto the Creler's back and began hammering at it with his shortswords. The Creler reared up and fell backwards. It crushed Ksmvr and then rolled on top of him. Now the Antinium was the one being savaged.

"*No!*"

Yvlon got up and swung her sword. The enchanted weapon *bit* into the Creler's armored back as Pisces and Ceria desperately blasted away the baby Crelers. The adult turned, not harmed so much as wary, and charged Yvlon again. This time it smashed into her force shield.

The impact made Yvlon brace herself, but the shield repelled the weight of the Creler flawlessly. Ksmvr got to his feet and slashed at the adult's back as one of the Crelers landed on Ceria. It had crawled onto the ceiling and got onto her neck. She cried out, reached for it—

Two spikes of pain tore themselves out of her neck. She screamed, fell, convulsing, as agony shot through her entire body. Something was digging at her flesh, and there was *burning*.

"Ceria!"

A hand tore the burrowing Creler away. Pisces threw the Creler aside and stabbed two as they crawled towards him with his rapier. He picked up Ceria and blasted the ground with fire, keeping the Crelers away.

The half-Elf was shaking, throwing up and burning at the same time.

“You’re poisoned. Can you stand? We have to retreat.”

“Ice—Ice—”

A sheet of ice rose and melted. Ceria couldn’t concentrate. Pisces cursed as he pulled her back. The adult Creler was smashing into Yvlon’s shield, driving her back. The woman swung her sword and this time the Creler charged onto it. The blade was deflected by one of its claws and it ran onto Yvlon’s arm, pushing her forearm at a bad angle. Yvlon’s gauntlet resisted the weight and pressure, then *bent*—

Yvlon stumbled back, one of her arms clearly broken as Ksmvr swung his swords, knocking Crelers away. Pisces was towing Ceria towards the entrance.

“We must run.”

“No. They’ll catch—”

Crelers never gave up. Ceria struggled to her feet, trying to think past the pain and poison. She raised her hands. Pisces looked at the ground. The first bear was right there.

“Give me a moment.”

They both said it at the same time. Ceria raised her hands. Pisces pulled out his wand.

“Rise, rise, oh fallen bear. To rend and bite, to rend and tear!”

“[Ice Wall]! Yvlon, Ksmvr, *move!*”

This time two walls of ice rose up, one on each side of Ceria. She took a breath and *pushed* them forwards as baby Crelers surged at her. Ceria ran forwards as the small Crelers were shoved by the moving walls of the ice, forced towards the adult. Ksmvr leapt over the walls of ice, clinging to the ceiling and Yvlon raised her shield as Ceria maneuvered the ice wall around her.

“I’ve got them in a corner! Back up! I’m casting a fireball!”

Ceria felt sick. She threw up as she was casting the spell, as the Crelers were swarming around the barrier of ice. She raised the wand, tried to focus.

“F—[Fireball]!”

There was heat. Light. The explosion kicked Ceria off her feet and blasted Crelers apart. The ones who survived the blast were set alight. They moved, still trying to kill but overheating. Ksmvr slashed at them, leaping down from the ceiling and crushing the ones that moved.

The adult had caught the fireball’s blast too, but it just hunkered down and let the armor of its body shield its organs. It rose as Yvlon circled it and charged her, biting, tearing. Yvlon tried to hack at it with her sword, but her arm—

“Now. Charge!”

The adult turned and a huge paw of bone smashed into what might have been its head. It didn’t flinch and lashed out. Futilely, for once. The skeleton of the bear took no notice of the tearing claws and rammed into the Creler, forcing it back.

“From the other side!”

And a second undead bear stood. Both bears began to smash the Creler from each side, battering it, smashing it into the ground. The monstrosity weathered the blows, tearing bones from each undead, biting—

“It’s too tough! The bears aren’t hurting it!”

Someone was shouting. Ceria was lying on the ground. She felt Pisces picking her up, and saw Ksmvr trying to maneuver around the fighting undead bears and adult Creler. Yvlon had her sword. She was casting aside her shield.

“Pisces! Move the bears! I have to do it!”

“Mordhau. Use the mordhau technique!”

Pisces roared at Yvlon as the two bears backed away. Both were gripping parts of the Creler with their jaws, forcing its attention away from Yvlon. Ceria saw the woman curse and change her grip on the sword. Clumsily, using her broken right arm and left arm together, she gripped the sword by the blade, raising the pommel.

“Now!”

One of the bears was being destroyed as the Creler smashed it into the ground with its superior strength. Yvlon shouted as she ran forwards. The pommel of her blade descended. It was enchanted with the weight spell. It crashed into the adult's back and went *through*. It tore open the black armor, deforming the shell under the weight of the blow.

Orange liquid gushed from the opening. The Creler reared up, turned. Pisces flicked his wrist and a bolt of magic shot from the ring on his finger. It pierced the Creler's exposed underbelly and then fragmented, becoming a splinter of magical needles which tore the thing open.

More orange and red liquid gushed forth. The Creler's insides burst and the deflated. It kept moving, keening, crawling towards Yvlon. She bashed it several more times, and then backed up. Ksmvr helped pull Ceria away as the adult kept crawling towards them.

It took twenty minutes to die, even without any of its innards. When it was done, Ceria lay on the ground, shaking, the poison running through her.

"It wasn't too much. You should be fine, but we *have* to get you to Octavia or a [Healer]."

Yvlon was kneeling by Ceria, watching out for stray Crelers. Ksmvr had her blade and was dicing up the remaining Crelers with Pisces and the undead bears. Ceria blinked at her.

"Your—arm."

The woman blinked and Ceria looked at her *bent* right arm. It looked horrible, and blood was leaking around one of the gauntlets, but Yvlon only shrugged.

"Can't feel it."

"Why? What?"

Ceria stared at her friend. Yvlon smiled crookedly. She raised her arm broken and waggled it horribly. It shifted and Ceria saw Yvlon's face change not one bit.

"I can't feel a thing."

“I think we’re done.”

Pisces spoke after a while. He staggered back to the cave entrance where Ceria was sitting up with Yvlon. The half-Elf was feeling better. She’d washed the spot where the Creler had dug into her neck with lots of water and some healing potion. The poison kept the wound from closing and it was horribly deep, but Ceria could think.

“You sure? We can’t leave a single egg behind.”

“Ksmvr was rather thorough. We have diced up every Creler we could find, save for the adult, and begun cremating the remains.”

“Did you get a count? We’ll need to testify under truth spell—”

Yvlon sat next to Ceria, wiping her gore-covered blade with snow.

“I counted eighteen small ones and one adult.”

“*Eighteen?* They felt like hundreds!”

“Only eighteen. Sorry. But you know what the bounty on Crelers is. We’ll earn a lot for each one. As for the adult, I hear it’s a two *thousand* gold coin prize for killing one!”

“Too bad that’s not an adult.”

“*What?*”

Pisces coughed.

“Ksmvr explained it to me. Ksmvr?”

He called and the Antinium walked over. Ksmvr was wounded in several places and there were pieces of chitin missing from his legs, one of his arms, and his shoulder. For all that, he appeared as unconcerned as Yvlon with his injuries.

“Yes, Comrade Pisces? I am attempting to destroy the junior Creler.”

“*Junior?* Oh come on. It’s got to be an adult! I’ve never seen one, but—junior?”

The Antinium nodded at Yvlon and Ceria’s shocked expressions.

“It is decidedly a juvenile example of the species. The ones we encountered en masse were hatchlings of course. But an adult is considerably larger. And it can fly. If we had encountered one such Creler, I doubt we would be alive. It takes many Soldiers to bring down a single adult.”

“Dead gods. No wonder the bounty on them is so high!”

“Indeed. On that note Captain, I am about to dismember and then destroy the juvenile Creler. I would ask that Comrade Pisces help me in incinerating the remains. I also caution you all to avoid eating any part of the Creler. Its eggs may incubate in your body and hatch if you eat it.”

The Antinium looked around in the sudden silence. He shrugged.

“The Antinium have learned this to our detriment. Crelers are not a valid food source for this reason.”

He went back to hacking at the Creler’s corpse. After a moment Yvlon tried to get up and go to him. She tried, because she attempted to use her broken arm to lever herself up until she realized what she was doing. Ceria put a hand over her mouth and Pisces frowned.

“Yvlon, your arm—”

“Can’t feel it.”

“It’s still *broken!*”

Ceria looked in horror at Yvlon. The other woman gave her a pale smile.

“I’m fine, Ceria. Once we get back—”

“I can correct the bones for you and use a healing potion now, if you like.”

Pisces squatted down by Yvlon’s arm and indicated the gauntlet.

“We must only remove the gauntlet first. I fear that will be troublesome —”

“No problem. We can do it. Don’t worry about me; I can’t feel it. Like I said.”

Yvlon gritted her teeth as Pisces tried to remove the bent armor. Ceria had to turn away when she saw the broken skin and protruding bone that

was Yvlon's arm. There was bent steel mixed in with the bone. Pisces hissed under his breath. Yvlon looked down at her arm with disgust, but again, without pain.

"Please hold still. I shall—correct the bones and refit them properly. You may wish to look away."

Pisces put his hands on Yvlon's arms and concentrated. The bones began to reshape themselves under her flesh. Both Yvlon and Ceria looked up and away as Pisces spoke.

"You are fortunate that I am present. Using healing potions to mend broken bones is often a futile or dangerous effort. However, in my case—please bear with the sensations for a moment."

"Like I said—"

"You really can't feel a thing, can you?"

Ceria stared at Yvlon. The woman's face was sweaty, but there was no hint of agony in her eyes. Just...a disturbed look. Yvlon nodded.

"I can't feel a thing. I, aha, have a Skill. [Ignore Pain]."

She twisted her arm as Pisces finished and lifted it. The bones were straight now, whole, despite the metal grafted to them, but the skin—Ceria felt the urge to throw up. Yvlon poured a healing potion on her arm and watched the skin run together like water.

"I've heard of older warriors earning Skills like [Lesser Pain Tolerance] which lets them fight on when wounded..."

When she felt she could look, Ceria stared at Yvlon and saw the other woman's twisted smile. Yvlon swung her arm about, testing it, and then shrugged.

"I didn't feel my arm break. I only noticed when I couldn't grip the sword properly."

"How?"

"It's a Skill I got. It's nothing to worry about, Ceria. I'm grateful for it, believe me."

"Tree shit."

“Bullshit, if you will excuse my language.”

Pisces and Ceria spoke at the same time. They looked at each other, and then at Yvlon.

“Pig shit. Bird poo. Squirrel feces. Lizard poo. Drake poo. Excuse me. I thought we were listing excrement.”

Ksmvr came over, covered in Creler goo. He cocked his head at the others as they laughed. Ceria shook her head and then glared at Yvlon.

“No one gets—[Ignore Pain] just like that. You’re hiding something, Yvlon. Why didn’t you tell us you couldn’t feel your arms?”

The woman smiled crookedly.

“Because I was grateful. Do you know how much it hurt the day before I slept...? Right after the dungeon, I mean. I was going to scream, but then I leveled up, gained my Skill...and a new class.”

“A new class?”

“[Wounded Warrior].”

Yvlon grinned at Ceria’s shocked expression. Pisces put a finger to his lips thoughtfully.

“Intriguing. I had not heard of such a class...I assume that Skill was one of the, ah, rewards for your transition?”

“The only one I have so far. It’s...I don’t know what to call it. But I could fight. Badly, but I could fight despite my arm breaking.”

“It’s not right. Yvlon, I’m so—”

“What do you want me to say, Ceria? I’m a cripple without that Skill. I wouldn’t be able to move my arms—I’d have to cut them off or scream myself to death. And without Pisces, I’d lose them anyways.”

Yvlon nodded at Pisces. He looked somber.

“I can repair your arms, but I regret that I cannot do anything about the iron fused with your, ah, flesh, Yvlon. It may be removed, but there is not enough bone to reconstruct your arms with afterward.”

“And you can’t...add more bone? I’ve never asked before, but...”

Yvlon nodded subtly at the two undead bears that were standing watch over the burning junior Creler. Ceria's mouth dropped open. Pisces eyes widened before he shook his head.

"Alas, no. Bones aren't that easy to use interchangeably, Yvlon. A bear's bones would be rejected by a human body. So too would any other bones, should you be curious. It is a...a function of your body that it would only accept your bone as part of 'you'."

"I see. I guess bones are more complex than I thought."

The woman laughed shortly. Ceria stared at her. Yvlon quieted after a moment and looked at Pisces.

"I hate [Necromancers]. I hate the undead."

Ceria opened her mouth, and then closed it. Pisces looked surprised, but not insulted. Yvlon sat up, flexing her formerly broken arm. She sat in the cave, the horrible smell of burning Creler in everyone's nostrils as she spoke, continuing their conversation from the wagon.

"My family is devoted to championing justice. We have a history of serving as [Knights], defending others. I've been raised to hate necromancy since I was a child and I still do. I think it's unnatural. Any [Necromancer] I meet I will cut down. I would never journey with any kind of spellcaster like that if I had a choice."

Pisces bowed his head silently. Yvlon eyed him, looked into Ceria's disappointed eyes and smiled.

"That's why I'll tolerate what you do. For you and only you."

A breath caught in Ceria's throat and she coughed as smoke made her eyes water. Yvlon pushed herself to her feet. She raised her sword, now clean, and indicated her arms. Metal ran into flesh, twisted, melded with her skin. It was an ugly sight, and haunting. She smiled unhappily.

"I'll be watching you, to make sure you're not misusing your magic. I, Yvlon Byres, a Level 26 [Wounded Warrior]."

Ceria took a breath. Telling someone your exact level was...it wasn't the most familiar thing you could do, but it was a show of trust. Among adventurers, it was a sign they were more than acquaintances. Pisces looked into Yvlon's eyes and then got up too. When he spoke, it was hesitantly.

“You may not know this, Yvlon, but when a [Mage] transcends into a unique class such as [Necromancer], [Cryomancer], and so on, they become...focused in that specific class. If they pursue other types of magic, they must begin with the [Mage] class again. From Level 1.”

He stared at her, and then Ceria. He gestured to the rapier at his side.

“Necromancers lack many direct spells to attack their foes. High level necromancers are different of course, but the strength of death magic lies in minions, spells which sap energy. It is said that necromancy, above other schools of magic, is the mastery of preparation. Yet armies of the undead and servants of this nature are feared. Hated. Despised. Despite what you may think, I wish to live among people without their disdain.”

Silence. Yvlon looked at him, waiting. Pisces closed his eyes.

“I have dreamed of being a [Necromancer]. It is my calling. My passion. Yet I love magic of all kinds. I wish to see what it can bring me. I wish to know...I hover on the cusp of power. I am a Level 29 [Necromancer], and a Level 18 [Mage].”

Level 29. Ceria’s breath caught. She hadn’t known. Pisces stood at the limit agreed by most to be one of the thresholds. At Level 30 he could call himself a Gold-rank adventurer regardless of his gear.

Pisces nodded to Yvlon. She nodded back. Both looked at Ceria. She realized what she had to do and scrambled to her feet. She nearly fell—she felt sick the moment her head moved. Yvlon and Pisces caught her. She grinned at them weakly.

“Ceria Springwalker. Level 25 [Cryomancer].”

They both blinked. Ceria smiled, suppressed the urge to throw up, and spoke.

“What? I got the class change yesterday. I guess it was a sign I was about to learn [Ice Wall]. I’ve been meaning to tell you all, but what with the Goblin Lord and the Named Adventurers popping up left and right, there was never a good time.”

“I’m glad.”

Pisces spoke to Ceria. He squeezed her arm, and she squeezed his with her skeletal hand. The last to rise was Ksmvr.

“I am Ksmvr, formerly of the Free Antinium. I am a Level 16 [Warrior].”

He looked at the others. They gaped at him. Ceria burst out first.

“*Level 16?* You’re so...weak! How are you only Level 16 when you can fight like...”

The Antinium looked guilty.

“I was Level 12 when we first met. The Antinium do not level, except in the case of Individuals. And I did not level much after my creation in the Hive, merely studied my predecessor’s history and assisted my Queen...”

He looked at the others and seemed to grow smaller. More hesitant. Ceria couldn’t believe it. She’d assumed Ksmvr was Level 20, at least! He fought like he was a veteran similar to any of the [Warriors] she’d met. Yvlon’s face showed the same amazement Ceria felt.

The Antinium seemed to sense the other’s disbelief. He spoke quietly, suddenly, afraid.

“Please do not eject me from your group. This is the only place where I have meaning.”

The other Horns of Hammerad looked at him, shocked. Ksmvr, who hadn’t trembled when being bitten by Crellers, shook like a leaf in front of them. Pisces let go of Ceria to rest a hand on Ksmvr’s shoulder.

“I doubt either Yvlon or Ceria would eject you from the group, good Ksmvr. I certainly would not, especially since you are the only one who listens to my advice. You are a valued member, and more so perhaps, given your potential to grow in strength.”

“Yeah, what he said without the fancy words. You’re one of us, Ksmvr.”

Ceria smiled at Ksmvr, and then fell over. The other Horns of Hammerad stared at Ceria as she lay on the ground and moaned weakly.

“I think the poison’s getting to her. Damn Crellers are nightmares. We need to get back to Esthelm, or better yet, Liscor at speed. Termin’s gone though. And it’s miles...”

Yvlon groaned as she stared out into the snow. The Corusdeer soup they’d all eaten was wearing off and it was cold. Pisces muttered to himself.

“It seems we must carry Springwalker. On a sledge, perhaps? Is it worth the effort of fashioning one?”

“I could attempt to carry her—”

As Ksmvr and Pisces debated, Yvlon looked around. She jumped as she saw the two undead bears staring at her. She frowned, looked at Pisces, and then hesitated. She looked back at the bears, and her eyes widened.

Slowly, she turned to the necromancer and cleared her throat. He looked at her, and Yvlon spoke very cautiously.

“I might regret saying this, but...Pisces, the Adventurer’s Guild banned you from using any corpses made from people, right? They never said anything about bears.”

For a moment Pisces stared at Yvlon. Then he grinned. Yvlon smiled and Ceria raised her head.

“I’m okay! What’s...what’s...?”

She looked up as Pisces and Ksmvr lashed her to a piece of wood. Yvlon had sliced down a tree with her sword and they were tying it together with some rope from Ksmvr’s pack.

“What’s...? Huh, Yvlon?”

The woman smiled down at Ceria. It was Ksmvr who explained.

“Bears.”

Later that day, the guards on the walls of Liscor would see a crude sled being pulled by two skeletal bears approaching through the snow. There would be much deliberation, but as Yvlon pointed out, bears were not people, and thus the city had no reason to object. That they did anyways was perfectly natural, but it marked the start of bear-based transportation for the Horns of Hammerad.

However, that event was not witnessed by Regrika Blackpaw, who was further in the city proper and did not pay attention to the commotion at the

gates. She was walking down one of the streets, nodding to Gnolls and speaking with the ones who approached, the center of attention.

At her side walked a Drake with dark purple scales, male, holding a staff. He was a Gold-rank adventurer, a [Mage]. The duo had already been invited to the party at Erin's inn that night and were heading there at their leisure.

Perhaps it was happenstance that they spotted the young Human woman as she jogged down the street. Perhaps not; Ryoka had just put in an order for a cured ham and other assorted meats to Krshia, and the Gnoll had assured her they would be brought in time for the party. She was on her way back to the Wandering Inn with Ivolethe, chatting, when the Named Adventurer spotted her.

Regrika recognized Ryoka. Of course she did. And thanks to Olesm, she had a name to put to the face. She reached out and touched the shoulder of the Drake [Mage] who walked beside her.

"Imenet."

She pointed and the Drake blinked his eyes.

"That's the Runner?"

"Yes. Let's intercept her."

Ryoka Griffin could hardly have missed Regrika Blackpaw heading her way. She was still surprised when the Gnoll called to her in the street and obligingly slowed down. Confused and a bit surprised, she waited for the Gnoll to speak.

"Hrr. You are Ryoka Griffin, yes? I am Regrika Blackpaw. May I have a moment of your time? I have been wishing to speak with you."

The huge Gnoll with black fur was a giant, and she smiled down at Ryoka. The young woman took the Gnoll's paw and shook it gingerly, catching the Named Adventurer's smell as she did.

"With me? Uh, how can I help you?"

"I am looking for a competent Runner, and I have been directed to you by one Olesm Swifttail as the best runner in the city. That is so, yes?"

She smelled of slightly damp Gnoll fur and that intrinsically animal smell of dog and something else. There was a hint of metal in that scent as well. Ryoka blinked up at Regrika Blackpaw.

“Are you sure you haven’t gotten the wrong person? I’m—a City Runner, not a Courier. And there’s one here. His name is Hawk and he’s way faster than me.”

“Hrr. That is what I have been told, yes. But the Courier known as Hawk has refused to go near the Goblin Lord’s army, and I am seeking anyone else with the bravery to venture close to it. Please, come and have a drink with me so that we might at least discuss it, yes?”

Ryoka hesitated.

“I’m honored, really. But I don’t think I’m the person you’re looking for. I—I’ve had enough of insane runs and risking my life for a while.”

“Ah, I see. But I hope you would listen to my offer first, then decide. Would you have a drink with me at the very least? I hope you are not too busy to do so.”

Again, Ryoka hesitated, but turning down an offer from a Named Adventurer struck her as a very rude thing to do. Especially one that Krshia and Brunkr loved so much. She looked around and didn’t see Ivolethe, so she shrugged.

“Okay. Uh, I know an inn—”

“There is a bar not far from here. It is closest. I would not want to waste any of your time, yes? Follow me.”

The Gnoll woman and the Drake set off, taking a rather quick pace. Ryoka was able to walk behind them and they soon went down an alley, presumably a shortcut to the rest of the city, Ryoka supposed. She tried to make conversation as she walked down the deserted path behind the Gnoll [Champion].

“I don’t want to disappoint you. I really don’t think I’d be willing to risk my life. There’s a party tonight with the Gnolls in Liscor. We could speak then—but I just can’t see myself doing anything as dangerous as scouting the Goblin Lord’s army. I have a…history with him.”

The Gnoll stopped in the dark alley. She half turned her head and smiled again at Ryoka. Her voice deepened and she cocked her head to one side.

“Oh? But you were quite happy to deliver a letter to the Necromancer himself a month ago. You ran through a battlefield and through his castle to do it. You trespassed and evaded his creations. You did this, Ryoka Griffin. Or had you forgotten?”

For a second Ryoka just blinked. Then she froze.

“The Nec—*how do you know that?*”

The Gnoll made no reply. She reached for her paw, and twisted something. A ring on her furry fingers. Ryoka felt something *shift*.

The smell in the alleyway changed. Gone was the smell of Regrika Blackpaw. And gone was the shape of her. Another being stepped into place as the form of the Gnoll adventurer vanished. A woman made of bone, a knight of ivory, turned. A perfect, carved face of white bone stared down at Ryoka, and two burning green eyes gazed down at her. An undead’s eyes.

Venitra reached out as Ryoka turned to run. She caught the Human girl by the throat and lifted her up.

“Hello, Ryoka Griffin. I have been searching long for you.”

Her lips of bone curved upwards in a smile. She tightened her grip.

“I trust that this will hurt greatly. And then you will die. You should never have trespassed. Now you will pay the price. You and everyone you love. I promise you that.”

4.28

Death. Ryoka felt its hand on her throat. She rose, suspended from the ground by the thick arm made of bone. She looked into two burning yellow flames embedded in the sockets of the undead woman.

Venitra.

She was as perfect as a sculpture, as tall and armored as any knight. And she was smiling.

No time for thought. No time to wonder how or why Venitra was able to pretend to be the Named Adventurer known as Regrika Blackpaw. Ryoka *kicked* at Venitra's face as hard as she could.

Her foot connected. It felt as though Ryoka had kicked a rock. Venitra didn't budge an inch. Nor did her grip waver.

"You will not escape me this time, Ryoka Griffin."

She could barely breathe. Ryoka's hands scrabbled at her belt pouch. She had to use—where was Ivolethe? Had to—

Venitra's hand shot out and tore away Ryoka's belt pouch. She tossed it to the ground. Her grip tightened on Ryoka's throat, cutting off air. There were black spots.

"Not so quickly, Venitra. Didn't you wish to torture her first? And we must ask her our Master's question."

Another voice. The crushing grip loosened just a fraction. Ryoka choked, and saw the Drake [Mage] was gone as well. The being that had called itself Imenet shed the illusion disguising it.

A black skeleton, bones polished and gleaming like metal stood beside Venitra, holding the magical staff. Her eyes were golden, flickering lights and she was grinning. It wasn't just her skeletal head. There was true malevolent joy in the way she looked at Ryoka.

"Let's ask her first. And then hurt her."

Venitra dropped Ryoka. The girl fell, twisted to get up and run, and sat down. A cold, boney hand was on her shoulder and the black metal bones

shone a bit in the light filtering down into the alleyway.

“She is paralyzed, Venitra. I have already put up an eavesdropping barrier; let me deter attention away from this place before continuing.”

“Do it, Ijvani.”

Venitra waited a moment as the black skeleton twisted her staff and spoke silently. Ryoka tried to move. She tried to shout, but she was a little ragdoll lying on the ground. Helpless, until Ijvani nodded. Only then did Venitra lean down and Ryoka could speak.

“Look, I—”

“Quiet.”

Venitra’s voice was deep, beautiful. She was manufactured to be perfect both as a weapon and as a piece of art, of that Ryoka was certain. She was Az’kerash’s servant. How was she here? Ryoka stared up at Venitra. There was emotion in the undead woman’s eyes. Hatred. Or—no, hatred was too strong somehow. It was more like disdain, the same look Ryoka had given the insect that crawled on her toothbrush yesterday morning.

“You have taken us a long time to track down. A very long time, Ryoka Griffin. For that you will pay.”

“Not too long. We’d have found her far sooner if you didn’t keep getting us lost.”

The echoing, hollow voice that was somehow feminine came from the black skeleton. Ijvani. Ryoka saw Venitra’s eyes narrow and she glanced at her companion with irritation.

“That was not my fault.”

“Was too.”

“We found her. That is all that matters.”

“Is that why you lied to our master yesterday?”

“Be silent, Ijvani.”

The dialogue between the two undead would have been hilarious if Ryoka weren’t so terrified. They spoke like—like bickering kids, or like

two comedians doing a bad routine. She held her breath as Venitra turned back to her. The lips carved of bone moved like they were real.

Venitra's face was expressive, lifelike. Ah, but the eyes. Her pupils were filled with the dancing flames, and they stared at Ryoka with nothing but malice.

"Ryoka Griffin. Who have you told about our master?"

Ryoka worked her mouth, and found she could talk. She spoke shakily, grateful that she could tell the truth.

"I haven't told anyone anything about your master. I swear it. No one knows I met Az'kerash or where he l—"

"Do not say his name. You are not worthy of saying his name."

Venitra's hand shot out. She grabbed one of Ryoka's fingers. Her pinkie, on her good left hand. Ryoka stared at Venitra.

"I didn't mean—"

"Suffer."

The undead woman smiled. Then Venitra snapped Ryoka's pinkie finger. Ryoka doubled over. She screamed—silently. Ijvani twisted her fingers and Ryoka's mouth clamped shut. Her throat moved, but no sound came out.

"She's telling the truth. I have cast a truth spell and she doesn't appear to have any artifacts on her that would allow her to lie."

"Good. Then our job is nearly done."

"Nearly, but not enough. You aren't precise enough, Venitra. This is why our master sent me with you."

Ryoka was doubled over. Pain was filling every part of her, but she could see, dimly, Venitra turning to Ijvani, gritting her teeth.

"He told me to pick my choice of tracker. You came because *I* decided it."

The black iron skeleton nodded calmly.

"Yes. And if I hadn't come, Oom would have come with you. We are both the eldest of our master's creations. You are the youngest, for all you are

first in his eyes. You lack experience. So he has said."

"I am his favorite."

"So I have said."

Ryoka was trying to get up, to run. She was on her knees and pushing herself up when a hand picked her up. Effortlessly. Venitra tossed Ryoka into a wall. Ryoka felt a flash of pain, and the world spun.

"Ask your questions, Ijvani."

"I shall. Observe, Venitra."

Another face bent down into Ryoka's line of sight. Two pale gold lights burned in black sockets. Ijvani spoke.

"Have you left any notes, spells, or other measures to inform others of my master's identity in case of your death or disappearance?"

"No."

Ijvani paused, looked over at Venitra. The giant bone woman nodded in satisfaction. She knelt by Ryoka and grudgingly spoke to Ijvani.

"Good."

Then Venitra smiled and reached out for Ryoka's hand again. She broke another bone. On the same finger. She grasped the pinkie finger, ignoring Ryoka's frantic blows to her arm and face, and broke the already broken bone in a different place. This time Ryoka's silent scream was long.

The two undead stared at the curled up human on the ground. Not dispassionately; there was a great deal of satisfaction on Venitra's face. Ijvani was harder to read for her lack of features, but her voice was pleased.

"She has told no one. I suppose we can kill her, then. But perhaps it would be better to let her live? Her disappearance would be noted."

Venitra turned her head towards Ijvani, clearly displeased.

"Our master gave me the authority to make decisions, Ijvani. This Human is not worth keeping alive."

The skeleton shrugged.

"The [Strategist] in the council meeting knew of her."

There was a flash of yellow light in Venitra's eyes. She shook her head.

"Inconsequential. I want her dead."

"As you wish."

Ryoka got up. The two undead looked at her as she cradled her left hand. She glared at them.

"People will come looking for me."

"Let them. I told you I would kill you. I will kill your friends and family too, Ryoka Griffin."

Venitra smiled down at Ryoka. Ryoka hesitated. She looked at the ground and then dove for her belt pouch. Venitra missed as she swiped for Ryoka, expecting her to try to run around her.

She had one hand in her belt pouch, reaching for one of Octavia's bags. Ryoka rolled, tore out a sealed bottle, and then sagged against the wall. A skeletal hand was on her shoulder again.

"She's certainly quick. No wonder you failed to catch her before. I wouldn't have failed of course, but you were not built for speed."

There was an audible grinding as Venitra stepped over to Ryoka.

"I will rectify that error now. Give me her hand, Ijvani. I'll start with that."

She couldn't move. Ryoka lay, helpless, as her left hand was offered up. Venitra inspected Ryoka's fingers. She smiled as she looked into Ryoka's eyes. She delicately pinched Ryoka's twice-broken pinkie and—

Someone shouted from the alleyway. It was distant, but it broke through the bubble of horror around Ryoka. She saw both Ijvani and Venitra look up. In an instant they changed.

Regrika Blackpaw stepped away from Ryoka and Imenet, the Drake [Mage] with dark purple scales, looked towards the alleyway. Both looked annoyed, but their features, voices, and the smell they gave off had changed in an instant.

"I thought you had put up a spell to keep others away."

Venitra, now looking like a Gnoll with black fur, growled at Ijvani. The Drake lashed his tail and replied testily.

“I did. Someone must be coming through this alleyway for a reason. My spell deflects attention, not trespass. Kill whomever it is quickly and get back to business.”

Ryoka tried to get up. She had to run, warn whomever it was—but she still couldn’t move a muscle. She lay on the ground, and now she heard a voice. A distinctive voice. She recognized it, and heard pounding footsteps.

“Come back here you damn Winter Sprite! I’ll teach you to pour snow over my—oh hey, what’s going on here?”

Relc charged down the alleyway, following Ivolethe as she flew past him. He blinked as he saw Regrika Blackpaw, Imenet, and Ryoka, lying on the ground.

The words that passed between the two undead were quick.

“Guardsmen. We can kill him—”

“Too suspicious. Drakes value their soldiers too highly. Venitra, wait.”

Suddenly, Ryoka could move. Imenet knelt and pulled her to her feet. Regrika smiled at Relc and approached.

“Hello, guardsman. We were on our way to visit an inn, but we seem to have gotten lost, yes? It is my fault. I thought this alleyway was a shortcut.”

“You okay?”

A clawed hand helped Ryoka up and she stared into two innocent, Drake eyes. Imenet guided Ryoka past Regrika and Relc blinked at her.

“Oh hey! I know you! You’re that Human, right? You lot sure are clumsy, falling all over the place. This is what happens when you don’t have tails!”

“Uh.”

Ryoka stared at Relc, and then looked over her shoulder. Regrika’s paw came down on Ryoka’s shoulders.

“You know Miss Ryoka Griffin, guardsman? This is a surprise, yes? I was seeking her aid, which is why we have met. But we have not been

introduced. I apologize. I am Regrika Blackpaw, and this is Imenet Southwing, my companion.”

“Oh! Hey, you’re those famous adventurers!”

Relc’s eyes widened and he snapped his fingers together. He looked at Ryoka with a great deal of surprise.

“You know these people? Wow. Wow. Hey, this is great! We can all go to Erin’s party! I heard it was for a bunch of Gnolls and I figured that was too much hair, but I’m in the mood for a drink!”

Regrika and Imenet exchanged glances. The Gnoll smiled.

“We would be honored, Mister...?”

“Oh, I’m Relc. Senior Guardsman in Liscor!”

“Very important, Regrika.”

“Hrr.”

“What was that?”

“Nothing. Why did you come down this alleyway, Guardsman Relc? And why are you covered in snow?”

The Drake [Guardsman] was covered in a layer of snow. He shook it off his scales like a dog and grinned.

“Funny story. I was minding my own business when one of those damn Winter Sprites came out of nowhere and hit me with a bunch of snow! Bastards. They do that all the time. Anyways, if you’re looking for Erin’s inn, you’re going the wrong way. Follow me!”

He waved the others down the alleyway and set a quick pace. Ryoka stared at Regrika and Imenet, afraid to move. Should she run? Then Regrika slapped a paw on her shoulder and grinned at her.

“Let us not delay, Miss Griffin. I would like a drink, and to visit this inn so many seem to know of.”

She leaned down as Imenet walked after Relc and whispered in Ryoka’s ear.

“You cannot run. If you cause trouble, we will kill the Drake and everyone we must.”

Ryoka had no doubt she would. Mechanically, she began walking down the alleyway as Relc began to chatter with Regrika and the Gnoll responded cheerfully. Out of the corner of her eye she saw Ivolethe flying around her. The Frost Faerie's face was worried as she flew by Ryoka's side.

She flew right past Regrika's face. The Gnoll blinked and batted at the Frost Faerie with a paw, missing her easily. She frowned, but then shook her head as Relc cursed at Ivolethe. The Frost Faerie disappeared into Ryoka's reclaimed belt pouch. Ryoka walked out of the alley and out of the city, the two undead right beside her. And all the while as Regrika called out to Gnolls and greeted the ones who came up to her, she wondered what she was going to do.

She was afraid. Ryoka's head was a maelstrom of thoughts, fears. She was ready to run, but understood she'd be dead the instant she tried. So flight was out. Ivolethe was vibrating in her belt pouch? Could she do anything? The Frost Faerie wasn't allowed to interfere, though. Bothering Relc was probably all she could do and that might have been pushing it as well.

They were going to Erin's inn. The undead had to be stopped. Mrsha was there, and Lyonette. And Erin. But—there was a bit of hope in Ryoka's heart as they trudged up the hill, Relc taking the lead. There were two groups of Gold-rank adventurers in that inn, and Zel Shivertail besides. Maybe, just maybe—

"I'm here! Where's the food—hey, that's a lot of Gnolls!"

Relc happily kicked open the door to the inn and paused as he saw a full room inside. Noise and light swept over Ryoka as she stumbled into the room, followed closely by Imenet and Regrika. The two adventurers stared around the room and the laughter and conversation stopped as everyone spotted the Named Adventurer and her companion.

"Regrika Blackpaw."

It was a susurrations around the room. Ryoka saw a bunch of Gnolls look up and her heart sank. Krshia and her nephew Brunkr were here with a group of Gnolls. That was right—they were celebrating Brunkr's new class! And they seemed both surprised and elated to see Regrika Blackpaw here.

“Honored Blackpaw, we are truly grateful for your presence. I am Krshia Silverfang. We did not think to invite you, but we would gladly offer the bounty of tonight’s dinner with you, should you desire it.”

Krshia hurried over with a group of older Gnolls, practically falling over herself to bow to Regrika. The Named Adventurer laughed and bent her head to politely sniff at Krshia as the other Gnoll did the same.

“I am not honored here, surely? We are all fellow Gnolls—I had heard of this inn from others and wished to visit. I would be delighted to share a meal with you, Krshia.”

She stepped away from Ryoka—out of necessity more than anything else. The other Gnolls practically stampeded over Ryoka in their desire to meet their hero. Ryoka used that opportunity to take a few steps away from Regrika, looking around cautiously. She spotted Halrac sitting at a table across the room.

Now would be the time to edge over to the Gold-rank adventurers and hint at...something. Ryoka could use a piece of paper maybe, or speak in code. She was about to move when she felt a clawed hand tug at her sleeve. She looked around and into Imenet’s smiling face.

The Drake leaned over and whispered to Ryoka. For a moment the noisy inn grew silent, and it was Ijvani’s echoing voice that spoke in Ryoka’s ears.

“Speak and die, Ryoka Griffin. We will destroy this inn and everyone within. If you do not resist, it will only be your death this night.”

The Drake let go of Ryoka and stepped back. Ryoka stared, and Imenet smiled.

“I regret that we cannot speak now, Miss Griffin. But I am sure we will have another opportunity later. Excuse me.”

He walked over to Regrika and began introducing himself as well. Ryoka stared at his back. No way out. They were still watching her. Listening to her? Could she do something covertly while they were busy?

She clenched her fists. Slowly, Ryoka took a seat at a table in the leftmost corner of the room, by the kitchen. She stared as Regrika and Imenet sat down at a table in the center of the room, looking for all intents

and purposes like famous celebrities dealing with the admiring Gnolls around them.

But Ryoka was sure they were staring at her. The girl looked around and took stock of the inn. It was crowded, again, mainly with Gnolls to celebrate Brunkr's class, but there were the inn's regulars as well.

Griffon Hunt, the Halfseekers, and the Horns of Hammerad were all occupying three tables next to the bar, laughing as Ceria stood on a chair and tried to mime something. The Horns of Hammerad looked...battered, as if they'd been in a fight. But they were all in high spirits.

That was her target. Ryoka glanced at Regrika and Imenet. Now they were sitting down, the center of attention. They weren't looking her way. Ryoka slowly got up—

“Don't.”

A voice whispered in Ryoka's ear. The young woman jerked in surprise and realized Ivolethe had left her belt pouch. The Frost Faerie hovered by Ryoka's ear, lost in the noise of the room, speaking quickly and urgently.

“There is a listening spell on ye. I see it.”

“What?”

Ryoka glanced at Ivolethe. The Frost Faerie's eyes were wide and serious.

“The black skeleton cast it on ye. She can hear all ye say. Not what *I* say—her magic cannot detect the fae. But she'll know in an instant should ye try to tell anyone else. And the bone woman is ready to slaughter everyone in here.”

Of course. Ryoka closed her eyes. Of course they wouldn't be that stupid! Idiot! She looked at Venitra and hesitated. So they'd know. They'd know the instant Ryoka said anything. What if she—

“They are watching you. Don't mistake the illusion. The black skeleton seems to be looking elsewhere, but she is staring *at you*, Ryoka. She hasn't looked away once.”

Imenet was indeed chatting and laughing with Krshia, his head turned away from Ryoka. But at Ivolethe's words, Ryoka immediately relaxed and pretended to be looking around the room again.

Trapped. That's what she was.

Ryoka clenched her hands together, gripping the table. She felt her pinkie move and doubled over in pain. Her broken pinkie finger—the agony there was actually suppressed by the sheer fear and adrenaline coursing through Ryoka's body.

The young woman shook as she stared at the undead, surrounded by laughing Gnolls. They'd kill everyone in seconds. But there was Griffon Hunt and the Halfseekers in one corner, and the Horns of Hammerad were with them too. Maybe—

Speak and die.

She had to do it. She had to shout it. And then Ijvani or Venitra would kill her. So make it quick. How could she tell everyone what was happening in as few words as possible?

‘They're undead pretending to be adventurers!’

No. Too slow.

‘They're Az'kerash's minions!’

Close.

‘Az'kerash sent them.’

Yes. That was it. Stand, shout as you point. And die. Obviously, try to roll away and duck, but she'll come for you. Venitra. Can the adventurers

beat them? There's no choice. Ryoka hesitated.

"Ryoka? Hey, are you okay?"

A face appeared in front of Ryoka as Erin waved a hand in front of her face. Ryoka jerked.

"Gah!"

She nearly fell out of her chair. Ryoka caught herself with her bad hand and choked on a scream. Erin steadied her and pulled her back upright.

"Whoa! That's weird. What's up, Ryoka? I haven't seen you all day! Did you have a good chat with Krshia? And can you believe that Regrika Blackpaw person is *here*? I saw you come in with her and Relc! Do you actually know her?"

Suddenly, there was Erin. Ryoka cursed and tucked her left hand under the table as she tried to grin at Erin.

"Erin! Erin. I—what did you say?"

"I said...did you meet that Regrika Blackpaw person? Hey, are you okay? You look pale and sweaty."

Erin frowned as she peered at Ryoka. The Runner girl could barely tear her eyes off of Regrika to look at Erin. She knew she looked terrible. Relc might not have noticed, but Erin would. But Erin couldn't get suspicious. If she did—

The [Innkeeper] was frowning and about to slide into a seat next to Ryoka when something flew in front of her face. Ivolethe scowled at Erin and flicked a bit of snow into Erin's eyes, making Erin shout in surprise.

"Begone, Erin Solstice. Ryoka Griffin is busy. With me. Your presence is not needed."

"Well excuse *me*. Grumpy faeries...hey Ryoka, I'll get Lyonette to take your order in a bit, okay? Sorry, but we're really busy as you can see!"

Erin backed away, spluttering and wiping at her face. Ryoka breathed out and looked at Ivolethe. Then, conscious of Imenet, she pretended to be

brushing at some dirt. Ivolethe floated in front of Ryoka, eyes serious.

“What will you do? You have heard her threat. I...cannot interfere. Perhaps—no. I could try if it came to it, but there are consequences, Ryoka Griffin. Dire ones.”

She stared at Ryoka. The young woman looked at her, and then around the room. Griffon Hunt. The Halfseekers. The Horns of Hammerad. She took a breath and pushed herself up slowly.

“I’m going to do it. I have to—I—”

She saw Ijvani—now pretending to be the male Drake known as Imenet—look up for a second. Ryoka clamped her mouth shut as the Drake looked over. Ivolethe made a hissing sound. She flew closer to Ryoka’s head.

“You will die. I see it.”

Ryoka stared at Ivolethe and slowly shrugged. The Frost Faerie stared into her eyes and closed hers. Then she looked at the door and grinned.

“Wait. There are others coming. Hold this moment for a few seconds longer. For here is—”

The door opened and two figures walked in. Zel Shivertail and Wall Lord Ilvriss. Zel immediately greeted Mrsha who came bounding over, and Ilvriss stared around the crowded room, sniffing with disdain. He looked around and saw Ryoka. She stared back.

Never in her life had she been so glad to see Ilvriss’ face in her life. The Wall Lord began to stride towards Ryoka until Zel pulled him back. The [General] dragged Ilvriss towards a table further away. But that was what Ryoka needed to see. She took a breath—

And Ivolethe slapped a hand over her mouth.

“Wait, I said! The fates are not done with tonight yet.”

Ryoka froze. Two minutes passed as she paused halfway out of her seat, and Lyonette waved her hands and tried to get Ryoka’s attention before giving up and placing a beef casserole in front of her. Ryoka ignored both. Her eyes were on the door. And then it opened—

And Brunkr walked in. He’d come back from using the outhouse. Ryoka sagged. But then the Gnoll turned and held the door open for—

Klbkch. And Xrn. The two Antinium walked slowly into the room and caused a hush of their own. They turned and Klbkch met Ryoka’s eyes. They found a table, sat.

Now was the time. Ryoka’s heart was beating out of her chest. She could see Imenet and Regrika staring at both the Drakes and Antinium. Were they enough? They had to be. Here were legends from the Antinium Wars. They had to be—

She didn’t want to die. Ryoka imagined a spell, a magical bolt blasting her to pieces, or Venitra just pushing her hand *through* Ryoka’s chest. She didn’t want to die, and she was sure she would. But they were here. They were going to hurt her friends. They’d sworn it. Venitra had.

No choice at all. When Ryoka spoke, it was shakily, to Ivolethe, her friend, as the Frost Faerie hovered in the air next to her.

“I’ll do it, Ivolethe. Just protect—make sure that when I do—”

She was *shaking*. The Frost Faerie looked at the two undead, narrowing her eyes. Ryoka choked on her words and tried again. She wasn’t prepared for Ivolethe’s smile.

“Hold a third time, Ryoka. Hold. Perhaps there will be no death tonight.”

“How do you...?”

“Their master calls.”

Venitra could hear everything Ryoka said. She could see everything Ryoka did. It was all thanks to a spell Ijvani had cast. The two undead chatted and ate their food normally, and all the while, waited, impatient for this farce to be over so they could kill Ryoka Griffin.

Of the two, Venitra was the most impatient. She hated pretending to be Regrika Blackpaw. Her illusion was sophisticated enough to fool a Gnoll’s nose, but it still required her to laugh, speak, and worst of all, eat. She hated eating. The food was obviously tasteless to the undead, and she would have to wash it out of her body later. She hated the disgusting way in which living things ate.

But she did it for her master. She kept her disguise up for him, and she would laugh and smile at however many Gnolls it took to accomplish his wishes. However, part of her wished Ryoka Griffin would try and alert her allies. She would relish a battle here. The Gold-rank adventurers she’d spotted would be an enjoyable challenge.

However, it seemed like Ryoka was content to wait. Venitra looked up as the door to the inn opened, letting more worthless creatures come in. She frowned as she spotted one of them, a big Drake with green scales. Something about him triggered a faint memory and she leaned over to whisper to Ijvani.

“Ijvani, who is that Drake wearing armor? The big one? I feel as though I should know him.”

The black skeleton, disguised as Imenet, was having a harder time eating than Venitra. She was only a skeleton, and as such, the food fell through her body, forcing her to subtly teleport it outside every time she took a bite. She looked up, spotted the Drake that Venitra was indicating, and froze.

“That is Zel Shivertail.”

Venitra sat up, a bolt of comprehension and hatred going through her body. She stared at Zel as he took a table across from her and began arguing with his companion, a Drake wearing many magical artifacts.

“The one who defeated our master during the Second Antinium War? He’s here?”

Ijvani nodded, not taking her eyes off of Zel. Venitra gritted her teeth.

“We should kill him.”

Pretending to speak to a Human [Barmaid] named Lyonette and refusing a refill, Ijvani shook her head at Venitra. She spoke to Lyonette and her voice echoed in the other undead’s mind.

“That is not our mission.”

“No, but he is our master’s enemy. It is worth killing him here. If you immobilize him, I can run him through.”

“Venitra, we cannot take such an action without permission from our master.”

“Do not order me, Ijvani. I am going.”

Venitra’s eyes flashed. She stood up, smiling at the Gnolls around her and pretending to be stretching. She reached for the sword at her side—

And heard a voice.

Venitra. Ijvani. I am very displeased with you.

Venitra froze. Ijvani sat up. They looked at each other and Venitra sat down. She mechanically responded to the Gnoll named Brunkr who was asking her about her exploits, letting a lesser part of her functionality take over the conversation. But the whole of Venitra, the part that mattered, was now focused on the voice.

The voice of her master.

There were no words Venitra had to describe her master’s presence in her mind. If Venitra had learned of religion, she would have called it as

being akin to a revelation. She worshipped her master, the Necromancer, Az'kerash without knowing what that word was.

It was bliss to hear his voice. But also—terror. Because his mental tone was not loving as it normally was. Instead, it was filled with anger. And Venitra feared her master's wrath more than anything in the world.

“Master. We are overjoyed to hear your commands. What have we done to displease you?”

Venitra spoke through the link that connected her to her master. In her mind they were words. Inwardly Venitra cringed, because she thought she knew why he was angry.

Venitra. Yesterday I asked you whether you had found the Courier who delivered the letter to me. You informed me that you were in Liscor and had been for a week now, gathering information in my name. You lied.

There was no denying it. Venitra shrank in her seat, and she saw Ijvani wince. She had feared to tell her master the truth, but she should have. He had found out about her lies, and so quickly too! There was surely nothing he didn't know, and now he was angry at Venitra for betraying his trust.

Hesitantly, Venitra spoke, pleading, beseeching.

“I—did not want to disappoint you, my master. There were complications on the road and—”

You lied.

The two words nearly shattered Venitra's spirit. She bent over the table, causing the Gnolls around her to cry out in alarm. Imenet assured them that she, Regrika, had only eaten too quickly. But the truth was that Venitra was writhing in agony inside.

“I beg your forgiveness, master.”

There was no response. Had her master left her? For good? Was he so disgusted that he wouldn't reply to her anymore, only speak to Ijvani? Venitra felt despair, and cried out, grasping for some measure of redemption.

“Master! We have found the person you seek. We know her name. She is called Ryoka Griffin and she is sitting in this inn at this very moment! We were about to dispose of her as you ordered—”

You found her? Show me.

Venitra instantly turned her head, relieved to be the eyes of her master. He could see and experience what she did, and she showed him Ryoka Griffin, sitting tense at her table, not touching her beef casserole.

Ah. That is her. It seems you have not completely failed me, Venitra.

The woman made of bone sagged in relief. She wasn't worthless. She looked back towards her plate, pretending to be eating the steak she'd been served with relish. On the way she saw a pair of Antinium, and the two Drakes. There was a pause and then she heard her master's voice adopt a quality she'd never heard in it before.

Venitra. Why is Zel Shivertail sitting over there with one of the Lords of the Wall? And why are *Klbkch the Slayer* and *Xrn the Small Queen* sitting in the same room?

Klbkch the Slayer? Venitra twisted her head back and looked at the Antinium sitting at one of the tables. Surely that wasn't—but if her master said so, it had to be. She gulped, and the steak went down smoothly. The rising trepidation in her soul did not.

“I...do not know?”

She stared at Ijvani. The skeleton sat up and pretended to be dabbing at her lips with a napkin. Her voice was very, very hesitant.

“Master, we were unaware of the Antinium’s presence until now. We did not think to inquire—”

They are staring at Ryoka Griffin, the very person you were about to kill. Both groups are staring at her. Why?

The two undead stared at each other in silence. Ijvani jerked her head towards Venitra. Venitra shook her head imperceptibly. She gestured at Ijvani with her fork. Ijvani froze and shook her head.

Venitra made a furious gesture. Ijvani sunk down lower. Her voice was a whisper in Venitra’s mind.

“We don’t know.”

There was silence. Both undead sank down at their table, ignoring the other Gnolls. At last, Az’kerash spoke in their minds, sounding weary, annoyed, and worst, resigned.

I suppose this is all that I can expect from you two. Perhaps my faith in you, Venitra, and you, Ijvani, was misplaced. Would Kerash have served me better, or Bea? I fail to comprehend...how you two can be so careless.

There was nothing worse in the world. Venitra hung her head low. She had to fight not to let the illusion of Regrika Blackpaw burst into tears. Imenet was having the same struggle. Az’kerash’s voice spoke in her head after a moment, clipped, and calculating.

Is this Ryoka Griffin aware of your natures? Do not lie. Ijvani.

“Yes, my master. We confronted her and questioned her. She has told no one anything of your nature. We were about to kill her when we were interrupted. We have told her that if she speaks, she will die—”

A poor threat in this room. Tell the Courier that you will not harm her or her friends at this time. Tell her that if she seeks a fight, there will be unnecessary death. Ensure that she does not call out. The odds are not in your favor, my creations.

Shock. Venitra and Ijvani exchanged glances, but Ijvani obediently began speaking to Ryoka. The Runner jerked and stared at them. Az’kerash’s voice began a murmur in Venitra’s mind.

A Courier with links to Drakes and Antinium both? No—her presence may have to do with the group of soldiers who infiltrated my castle. If they managed to follow her through my defenses—

She had no wish to interrupt her master’s thoughts or draw more ire towards herself, but Venitra had to correct him. She felt wrong doing it, but she spoke up out of duty.

“She is a Runner, master. A City Runner, not a Courier.”

A City Runner? You are sure?

There was shock in Az’kerash’s voice. Venitra sent a mental approximation of nodding, very worried. Another pause, and then Az’kerash spoke to both Ijvani and Venitra.

Will she take action, Venitra? No? Good. Now. Look around again. Ijvani, monitor Zel Shivertail and the other Drake. Venitra, inquire

about the Antinium. Subtly. I wish to understand what is transpiring here.

Obediently, his servants did just that. Regrika Blackpaw suddenly became the center of the table as she inquired politely about the two Antinium. Imenet casually turned his seat so he could stare at the two Drakes out of the corner of his eye.

And across the room, Xrn and Klbkch were talking. They glanced over at Ryoka, and Xrn shook her head as she waved at Lyonette for service. Meanwhile, Zel and Ilvriss seemed to be arguing, and the Wall Lord kept standing up and being yanked down by the [General].

And they were all looking at Ryoka. The Runner wasn't aware of this at first. She kept staring at Venitra and Ijvani. But she couldn't ignore the others' attention for too long.

Thanks to the spell Ijvani had cast, they all could hear Ryoka as she looked around and spotted first Klbkch and Xrn, and then Zel and Ilvriss and noticed them staring. The Human girl seemed to speak to herself a lot.

Venitra, Ijvani, and Az'kerash all heard Ryoka's muttered words as she realized that Klbkch, Xrn, Zel, Ilvriss, and the disguised pair of undead were all staring at her corner table in turns.

"Oh fuck me sideways."

Some people might have called it funny. Three different groups, all intent on the same person, all at odds with each other, even if some of them didn't know it. It was a classic Balerosian Standoff, and an impartial watcher might see the humor in it. The participants did not.

Ilvriss leaned over to Zel, hissing at him as he stared daggers at Klbkch and Xrn. He glanced over at Ryoka, at the Antinium, and gripped the handle of his sword tightly.

“Shivertail. Why are the two Prognugators here tonight? Is this some kind of Antinium trick?”

“Calm down, Ilvriss. I don’t know why they’re here either. They might have been watching us, or they have business with Ryoka as well.”

“Tonight? This is no coincidence! Either there’s a leak or we are being spied upon.”

“Funny, I thought we were trying to spy on them.”

“Don’t make light of this! We have to know what they want with Ryoka Griffin. Watch them, Shivertail.”

“I am.”

“If they make a move, we must be ready—”

“I know. Just keep calm. Keep...calm...”

A few tables away, the two Antinium sat and stared at Ryoka Griffin and the two Drakes. Xrn coughed gently.

“Klbkchhezeim, why are the two Drakes here today?”

“Ah. I trust you are referring to the presence of Zel Shivertail and Wall Lord Ilvriss? I am uncertain. Zel is generally present for dinners. Ilvriss is an unknown factor. I suppose it is simply an unfortunate coincidence.”

“I see. They are glaring at us, Klbkch.”

“Yes. I suppose we upset them.”

“Our aim is not to upset them. I’ll try waving at them and see if it calms them down.”

“Ah.”

“Hmm. They really didn’t like that.”

“No, they did not. Perhaps I should try, Xrn?”

“I believe that would be most entertaining, Klbkch. Wave at Shivertail. Or better yet, buy him a drink.”

The first group to go over to Ryoka was Zel and Ilvriss. The Wall Lord got up at last, too furious to be restrained by Zel any longer. He marched over to Ryoka and took a seat at her table, uninvited. Ryoka blinked at him.

Az’kerash and his creations watched. The Necromancer mused quietly, his words heard by them and no one else.

Zel Shivertail and Wall Lord Ilvriss. They were the two who fought outside my castle a month ago. They clashed with my disciple and now end up here? Why? This is curious.

They heard the entirety of the conversation between them. It started out with threats, and insults. Ilvriss leaned over the table, making Ryoka lean back.

“You will tell me what I need to know. No more excuses! I demand—”

Zel pulled the Wall Lord back and smiled at Ryoka.

“You have to understand our position, Ryoka. When a group of soldiers goes missing, especially elites—”

“Did you kill them or not? How did they die? How did Periss—”

Ilvriss pounded the table. Venitra could make no sense of it, but Az’kerash put the pieces together quickly.

Ah. The Drake and Gnolls that Kerash and Bea disposed of. It has attracted the Wall Lord’s attention. This is...unfortunate. Yet it seems that Ryoka has refused to tell either Drake anything, despite their pressuring her.

Indeed, the next image all three watchers saw was Ryoka offering a single finger in reply to Ilvriss.

“Runner’s code, asshole. I can’t tell you a thing, even if I wanted to! I’m sorry, but that’s how it is.”

Ilvriss nearly strangled her, but Zel held him back. He was trying to argue with Ryoka, but his words weren’t that effective while Ilvriss uttered threats and tried to grab Ryoka over the table. However, the City Runner clearly had more on her mind. She glanced over at Ijvani and Venitra.

“Look, I’m really, really not looking to discuss anything tonight. Maybe later. In fact, why don’t you uh, turn around and piss off? That’d be helpful. Thanks.”

The two undead watched Zel forcibly pull Ilvriss away. Az’kerash’s tone was exasperated.

And you decided that the best course of action was simply to kill her? Why?

Ijvani and Venitra shuffled in their seats without saying anything. They heard a sigh in their heads.

You fools. *This* is why I ordered you to assess the situation before making any decisions! If this Ryoka Griffin disappears, this Wall Lord is sure to take interest. As for Shivertail—you are fortunate that your incompetence prevented you from taking her life earlier.

“Yes master.”

“Yes master.”

We shall speak with Ryoka Griffin now. I wish to know why the Antinium are here. They concern me—greatly. I was under the

impression that Liscor's Hive had produced nothing of value save for its strategic placement. I want to know what the Small Queen intends. She is dangerous.

When Regrika Blackpaw walked over, Ryoka was prepared for the end. She was prepared for a fight, for threats, for anything and everything.

But she was not prepared for a smile. As Regrika sat down in front of Ryoka, she was smiling. She smiled and Ryoka stared. Perhaps it was just the illusion spell. But it was mimicking Venitra's true expression, and for an instant, Ryoka saw nothing but simplicity in her smile. It was happy, guileless, and...innocent.

A child's smile.

Ryoka had no idea why, until Regrika, or rather, Venitra, spoke.

"My master is here. He wishes to speak with you, Ryoka Griffin."

Ryoka stared. She looked around and caught herself. She stared at Regrika.

"Here? In you?"

"I am watching and listening through my servant's eyes, Ryoka Griffin. I am present. We have met before."

The voice came from Regrika's mouth, but it was neither the Gnoll's voice, nor Venitra's voice. It was male, educated, precise, and old. It was horrifically disturbing to see it come from the female Gnoll's face. But it was Az'kerash's voice.

The Necromancer's.

Ryoka felt the floor open up. She saw Ivolethe flying towards her and tried to shoo her away. But the Frost Faerie alighted on Ryoka's shoulder. She hissed and glared at Regrika. Ryoka saw the Gnoll's eyes flick to her shoulder and frown, but oddly, the Necromancer didn't seem to notice Ivolethe at all.

“Look straight at Ryoka Griffin, Venitra. Thank you. Now, Ryoka Griffin, I believe you know why my creations are here.”

“To kill me?”

“Perhaps. But not necessarily. They were sent with instructions to ascertain whether you had spoken of my existence to anyone else. They were *not* commanded to kill you outright. They have failed me and for that they will be...reprimanded.”

Something about the way he said it made Ryoka feel that Az’kerash wasn’t a very forgiving and nice master. Venitra certainly seemed frightened. The ears of the Gnoll sitting in front of Ryoka flattened, and her tail drooped.

“So I’m not going to die?”

That was all Ryoka could think to ask. She’d been prepared for death the instant she met Venitra. To suddenly hear that it was off the table was...disturbing. And relieving. She dared to hope, and because she was an idiot, she tried to take a gulp from her full mug for the first time that night.

With her left hand. The instant Ryoka tried to move it, she agitated the broken finger. Ryoka bent over the table, swearing, holding her left hand with the three fingers of her right hand. Why was her hand always getting injured? Oh, right. She’d shattered both her legs before too.

Her finger was swelling up horribly now. It was badly broken, and Ryoka was afraid to show it to anyone. Somehow, Az’kerash noticed it as Venitra stared at her. Maybe she’d told him, although Ryoka doubted it.

“What is the matter? Ah. Your finger. My servants are careless. Allow me to rectify the issue.”

Regrika raised her paw and pointed at Ryoka’s left hand through the table. Ryoka felt something *shift* in her hand and jerked. She stared as the bones in her pinkie rearranged themselves and *snapped* back into place.

It hurt like hell in those moments, but the sensations of her bones *changing* on her were more terrifying than the pain. And then it was all gone. Ryoka stared at her pinkie. It was still puffy and swollen, but it barely hurt now compared to before.

“A healing potion will correct the rest of the damage.”

Az'kerash's voice was dismissive. Ryoka stared at him. She'd heard from Pisces himself that [Necromancers] couldn't change around people's bones unless they had direct physical contact. Apparently that didn't apply to Az'kerash.

"I should say thanks. But your minion broke my finger to begin with. Does this mean you'll leave me alone now?"

The look Venitra, or rather, Regrika gave Ryoka could have killed. Her big paws tightened on the table, but Az'kerash's voice was cool.

"I am still determining the risk you pose. You claim to have kept my secret—"

"And I will. Totally. Runner's Code and all that. I know what happens if I let anything slip."

Ryoka raised her hands. Venitra growled at her.

"Do not interrupt my master!"

"Calm yourself, Venitra."

Two voices, one body. Ryoka held still. Az'kerash's next words were musing.

"Tell me, why did the Dragon choose you of all people? It seems odd that he would assign such a delivery to a mere City Runner."

Ryoka gritted her teeth and forced a smile.

"He didn't. He put up an open request and I took it because it paid well. Believe me, if I'd known it would have resulted in this, I wouldn't have done it for all the gold in the world."

"Hah. That *is* amusing. So much trouble over a Dragon's whim."

Regrika's face didn't change, but Az'kerash sounded like he was enjoying some dry humor. He paused.

"I understand both Wall Lord Ilvriss and Zel Shivertail are interested in you because of your delivery to me."

"You killed Periss, his lieutenant. Or didn't you notice?"

"They were disposed of by my creations. I had paid little attention until now. If the Wall Lord received the remains of his soldiers, would he be

appeased?”

“Nope. Well, maybe. He wants to know why they died.”

“Ah. Inconvenient. However, it is a rectifiable situation. Hm. I have one more question for you, Ryoka Griffin. Why are there two of the Antinium in this inn?”

Ryoka hesitated.

“I’m good friends with Klbkch.”

“You are concealing the truth.”

“Get that from a truth spell? I’m not plotting against you, if that’s what you want to know.”

“That is part of what I wish to know, but it is...enough for now. For now, know this Ryoka Griffin. I do not desire my presence to be known. For that reason, I will guarantee your safety for now. My creations will not harm you.”

“And if you change your mind?”

Az’kerash paused. His voice was very cold.

“Give me no reason to. Understand, you have little say in this, Ryoka Griffin.”

No say. No choice. She was helpless. Perhaps that was true, but Ryoka’s temper flared. She leaned over the table, glaring at Regrika and not caring about how it looked.

“Oh yeah? What if I tell Zel Shivertail about you? You’re not here right now—this Venitra person and Ijvani are. If Zel kills them, what can you do about it?”

The voice that replied through Regrika’s mouth was icily unconcerned.

“What gives you the impression that would be an intelligent decision, girl?”

“He kicked your ass once in the Second Antinium War. He killed you, although I guess that part was wrong. What’s to stop him from doing it to your precious servants?”

Ryoka grinned at Regrika, and the Gnoll glared back. But it was Az'kerash who spoke again. His voice was impassive, and for that reason, terribly scary.

“If you wish to try, by all means speak. You and everyone in this inn will surely die. But if you think it is worth the cost, then allow me to give you this.”

A paw rose, reached out, and touched Ryoka on the lips. She jerked back, but it was too late. Something heavy gripped her tongue for a moment, and then was gone. Ivolethe cried out into Ryoka's ear.

“Death magic! The executioner's axe hangs over your head, Ryoka! *Do not speak!*”

Az'kerash spoke as Ryoka held very still, afraid to open her mouth.

“[Word of Death]. Speak any part of my name, Az'kerash, or mention necromancy and you will die in that instant.”

She stared at him, all her confidence lost again. The second intelligence hiding behind Regrika's eyes flickered, and then vanished. Regrika got up. Without a word, she left the table. Ryoka sat there, ready to puke. She wanted to run and realized suddenly that there was nowhere far enough she could go.

And then Ryoka realized that Regrika and Imenet were sitting at their tables, joking, talking about sending Ryoka to scout the Goblin Lord's army, acting like everything was normal. But underneath the illusion the undead were still there. And so was Az'kerash. They were still watching her. And as Ryoka sat up and realized Klbkch and Xrn were still waiting to speak with her, she got really nervous.

“Ryoka Griffin. May we sit with you?”

There had to be a way to tell people to go away without saying or doing anything to indicate that. However, Ryoka's best 'leave me alone' posture and the glare in her eyes did nothing to dissuade Klbkch. He took a seat and the strange blue Antinium sat next to him.

Ryoka recognized her at once. She was Xrn, the Small Queen, a legend and one of the big players in the Second Antinium War. Normally Ryoka would have been freaking out about meeting her, but after speaking with Az'kerash, this seemed frighteningly normal.

"I believe we have not met, Miss Ryoka Griffin. I am Xrn."

"Hi, Xrn."

Ryoka stared at Xrn. Maybe if she acted weird or rude enough they'd leave. She really did *not* want to talk about dead gods here, or anything—anything, really. Az'kerash was listening.

"I have wished to speak with you for a good deal of time. However, issues in the Hive have necessitated me remaining below ground. Pawn may have informed you that our Hive experienced an attack by many monsters from Liscor's Dungeon. They have been repelled—at cost."

"Oh?"

Ryoka wished there was a way to tell Klbkch *not* to be so helpful at explaining things. But Klbkch only took that as a sign to keep going.

"Indeed. However, the development of the unique group of Antinium Soldiers under Pawn has led to—"

"Hey Klbkch, let's not talk business right now. I think we should all just relax and—*not* discuss anything important."

Klbkch paused. He looked at Xrn. The other Antinium stared at Ryoka.

"You told me that she was aware of everything, Klbkch."

"She is."

The Antinium cocked his head at Ryoka.

"I know you are busy, Ryoka, especially given Regrika Blackpaw's offer to you. That is why I wish to converse with you and Xrn now. We may not receive another chance for a while. You see, Xrn is preparing to l—"

Ryoka gave up on subtlety and kicked him as hard as she could under the table. She heard one of her toes crack and felt blinding pain. The Antinium paused and looked down at his undamaged shin as Ryoka leaned over the table, making incoherent sounds of pain.

“Hm.”

He wasn’t an idiot. He and Xrn exchanged looks, and then turned to stare at the two Drakes who were watching them. And Typhenous, who was also watching. And Pisces who was eying her warily and glancing at Regrika and Imenet for some reason. And most of the other guests in the inn, who turned away and pretended to be doing something else.

“Ah, I believe I see Miss Ryoka’s objection, Klbkchhezeim.”

Klbkch shrugged.

“We *are* under a spell of silence, Xrn. They can’t tell what we are saying.”

Ryoka glanced quickly over to her left. Ivolethe shook her head definitively. Az’kerash’s spell was still in effect, silence spell or not. The young women thought quickly.

“This is *not* a good time, you two. I have that Wall Lord guy breathing down my neck. Let’s agree to not do or say anything with each other at all. Deal?”

This time both of the Antinium stared at Ryoka. Suspiciously.

“Have you been threatened, Ryoka Griffin? If you have, my duty as a Senior Guardsman and ally to you and Erin permits me to directly offer you the assistance of my Hive.”

“If she *is* being threatened, Klbkch, she wouldn’t say.”

Xrn reached over and prodded Klbkch in the head with one finger. She peered at Ryoka and the hearts of one Human and one Frost Faerie at the table stopped for a second. Xrn shook her head.

“I detect no magical enchantments on her. However, I agree with her desire for caution. I believe I have seen enough in any case. She knows what we plan to do. If she is an ally, she will prove herself as one. If not—”

The blue Antinium's eyes swirled blackly for a moment. A wisp of yellow was extinguished by a shade of black that color had no words for.

“—If not, we shall see. Now, I wish to eat more of this innkeeper's cooking before I leave. Tersk was telling me about it. Klbkch, let us eat. I have a spell I wish to try—[Stomach of the Cow]. [Powerful Digestion]!”

She cast the two spells as she walked away from the table. Ryoka watched her go.

“[Stomach of the Cow]? The hell's that? Is that a real spell?”

Klbkch hesitated before nodding. He stood up.

“Xrn is a prodigy among spellcasters, Ryoka Griffin. I am unsure of her mechanisms, but she is able to create new spells based on ones she already knows. It is part of her class. She may have learned this spell before, or created it. I will now aid her in consuming Erin's food supply and pay for her meals with my limited income as a [Guardsmen]. Good night, Ryoka. We shall speak at some other time.”

He nodded to Ryoka and turned away. Ryoka watched him go and then collapsed onto her table. Ivolethe flew down beside her and shook her head.

“Hah! That one can't spot magic to save her life! Although the spell cast *is* subtle. Yet she can see me, I think, and my sisters! When did mages become so useless?”

Ryoka put her head down and didn't respond. The table was cool—until Ryoka found a sticky spot with her cheek. She sagged in her chair and desperately wished the night was over. Unfortunately, it was just getting started.

Everyone had spoken to Ryoka, and gotten less than satisfactory answers out of her. That was true. But it didn't mean they were about to

leave. Indeed, all three groups were sitting in place. And unfortunately, Erin's renovations to her inn hadn't been completed yet, so there was a limited amount of space to put between all three parties.

Zel Shivertail glared at Klbkch across three tables, hand tight on his mug. Xrn and Ilvriss locked stares over Xrn's raised fork filled with spaghetti. Venitra and Ijvani studied the two, as Az'kerash stared through their eyes, pondering, assessing.

The other diners in the room had certainly noticed the power plays and interactions. That was why they had cleared a space. No one wanted to be caught between the Antinium and Drakes. Indeed, the atmosphere was getting tenser by the minute. No one dared break it, not even the Gold-rank adventurers.

Silence fell over the inn as Xrn chewed at some spaghetti with her mandibles. Zel's hand *cracked* on his mug. Ilvriss' grinding teeth could be heard in the quiet. Regrika Blackpaw sat and watched.

And then there was Erin. She edged right through the staring contest, holding a big pan and shouting.

"Make way! Cake! Make way for the cake! Oh, hey Mister Zel and you. Do I know you? And hi Klbkch! You and your friend will want to eat this. Wait, do I know *you*?"

Everyone stared. They stared at the fluffy pink frosting on the white background of the cake, the huge rectangular block of icing and cake, and at the letters on top. A simple word.

[Knight].

The class was spelled out on top of the cake in pink, and set about with glowing candles. Erin gently put the cake in front of the bewildered Brunkr.

"Surprise! Krshia said this was a party for you, and I've been *dying* to make a cake! So...happy class day, Brunkr! Blow out the candles and make a wish! Wait! We've got to sing happy birthday first!"

Erin began teaching everyone the happy birthday song. It was surprising how many people she got to join in. Ilvriss was not one of them. Xrn and Klbkch were. So was Zel.

Ryoka did not sing. She was trying to alternately stab her eyes out with her fork and hide under the table at the same time. She watched as Regrika Blackpaw got up and sang happy birthday, looking as happy as could be and wondered if Az'kerash could hear *that*. Then she wondered if he was joining in.

Brunkr gingerly blew out the mostly melted candles after that, and then there was cake. Cake.

“Have a slice, Ryoka! It tastes just like home! Go on!”

Ryoka stared down at the pink corner piece of cake she'd been given. She looked at Erin's beaming face, took a bite, and tried not to puke. She managed to get rid of the cake, mainly by feeding it to Ivolethe and Mrsha. She could have probably just dropped it on any table and it would have been gone, though.

The inn had gone crazy over cake.

“This is the greatest thing I've ever had!”

Relc was crying as he gobbled down his piece of cake. He licked his plate and then began demanding to know how it was made, how much it cost, and where he could get more of it from Erin. He was joined by Revi, Jelaqua, and a hyperactive Mrsha who was practically vibrating in place.

If that were all, Ryoka would have gotten down on her knees and thanked the non-discriminate and blessed ways of the Flying Spaghetti Monster, which was the only deity she was prepared to worship in this world. However, it seemed like Regrika's fame meant that everyone wanted to speak with her, and Ryoka happened to be a fine way of introducing oneself via proxy.

“Hey Regrika. Let me introduce you to my friends.”

Ryoka's smile twitched as she was forcibly prodded into place. The Named Adventurer looked up from her half-eaten piece of cake and saw the Horns of Hammerad clustering behind Ryoka, practically holding her in front of the famous Gnoll like a shield.

“Oh? Who is this? I am always happy to meet other friends of yours, Ryoka Griffin, yes?”

She smiled broadly at Ryoka. Ryoka gave her a return grin full of teeth.

“Great. These are adventurers. This is Ceria. She’s an ice mage. This is Yvlon, a [Warrior], Ksmvr, an Antinium [Warrior]—”

“I am pleased to meet you, Regrika Blackpaw. I understand you are famous. May I ask what your fame is derived from? I—why are you kicking me, Captain Ceria, Yvlon? I am only asking—”

“And this is Pisces.”

Ryoka ignored Ksmvr as the Antinium was dragged back. She smiled, and Imenet raised his head.

“Ah, a fellow mage? What is his class?”

Everyone looked at Ryoka. She gritted her teeth. Why couldn’t he have asked *Pisces* that? She spoke slowly, conscious of the [Word of Death] spell prohibiting her mentioning the N word. [Necromancer]. Frankly, the other N word wasn’t really an issue at this moment.

“Pisces? He...likes dead bodies. Animating them, commanding them. He’s got a fetish for that. Magical.”

Everyone stared at Pisces. He turned bright red and glared at Ryoka. Erin looked blankly at Ryoka, and then laughed and leaned over the table to address Imenet.

“He’s a [Necromancer]. I think Ryoka’s trying to be polite.”

“Ah.”

Imenet inhaled his breath and exchanged a glance with Regrika. The Gnoll stared at Ryoka and she glared in a friendly way at her. Pisces was the one to break the silence. His face was beet red.

“Allow me to assure everyone present that my, ah, obsession with the deceased is in no way sexual, as Miss Griffin seems to have intimated. I am a [Necromancer] out of academic interest, nothing more.”

He stared at Ryoka. She didn’t look his way. Regrika spoke slowly, staring at Pisces.

“I take no offense. I am aware of the stigma [Necromancers] face, but I myself consider it a worthy class. All magics are equal in principle, and those who pursue the heights of power are to be commended no matter what route they take. So I believe...yes.”

There was a pause after that last ‘yes’. Ryoka glanced sharply at Regrika. She wondered if it was Venitra who’d said that. Or her master.

Regrika Blackpaw’s words caused a stir at the table, and made Pisces flush with pride. He introduced himself and the other Horns of Hammerad stepped forwards eagerly to talk more as well. He shook hands with both Regrika and Imenet and paused for a second as he stared at Imenet. Then he retreated and let the other Horns of Hammerad introduce themselves.

“Everything okay? You like the food?”

Erin popped by, oblivious to Regrika’s rank and fame. She looked more concerned about the two adventurers’ plates, which were mostly cleared. Regrika smiled up at her and patted her stomach.

“It is most delightful, yes? I have seldom had finer food and I am grateful for it after many days on the road.”

“Indeed. I’m quite impressed by your abilities, Miss Solstice.”

Imenet smiled as well. Erin beamed in relief. Then Regrika looked down.

“However, I seem to have attracted a youngling around my feet. Who is this?”

Half of the Gnolls exclaimed and Krshia leapt to her feet as Mrsha’s head popped up next to Regrika. Lyonette rushed over, chagrin clear on her face, but Regrika only laughed. She peered at Mrsha’s white fur and stroked her head.

“Hrr. What a delightful child. Is she one of yours?”

Regrika looked around the table. The faces of the Gnolls froze over for a second and Erin coughed.

“Uh, that’s Mrsha, Miss Blackpaw. She’s—well, she’s part of the family at the inn, really. Her family was—uh—”

She trailed off, and Regrika took the hint. She smiled sadly down at Mrsha who hadn’t been listening to Erin’s words. Regrika offered Mrsha a bit of her steak and the Gnoll happily accepted it and sniffed at Regrika, smiling and wagging her tail.

Imenet took that opportunity to slide half of the contents of his plate onto the floor while no one was looking. As the conversation started back up, the topic of chess was brought up.

“Oh? You play the game? I was unaware that the game had spread so widely across the continent. When I learned of it I was intrigued, but there are few partners for me to play on my travels.”

This time Ryoka was sure that it was Az’kerash speaking through Imenet, not Ijvani. Erin grinned as she showed the Drake her magical chessboard and then her non-magical ones.

“You like to play? That’s great! I’m pretty good at the game myself. Want to play a game?”

“I should like that very much.”

There was no way for Ryoka to stop the game between Erin and Imenet, or rather, Az’kerash without upsetting the table or tossing a pot of soup over everyone. She considered that, but decided it was better to let them play. After all, what harm could it do?

The first game was slow. Imenet was white, Erin was black. They played a game through, attracting Olesm, Typhenous, Pisces, and Klbkch’s attention while everyone else wandered away. The audience wandered back when they heard Olesm screaming about how amazing it was.

“What a game!”

The Drake threw up his hands and danced about. Ryoka stared at the board. It had been...a damn good game. And it was even better because Erin had won. She grinned as she watched Imenet sit back, a look of amazement on his face. Across the table, Regrika’s jaw looked like it was about to hit the floor.

“Every move I made was optimal. And yet I was defeated.”

Az’kerash spoke quietly. Erin laughed and slapped Imenet on the back.

“You were great! How did you learn to play like that? It was a great match, like Olesm said. But the difference was that I had a different style.”

“Indeed. I have not encountered anything like it. You flanked my approach most spectacularly.”

Erin nodded and took on the lecturing tone of a hardcore fan of chess.

“It’s called the hypermodern play style. You had a really, *really* good control of the center at the start, but it was all pawns. But my strategy was all about controlling the center through indirect pieces, see? I keep telling Olesm it’s a really good style of play, but he’s stuck on pawns like Belgrade...”

Olesm turned bright red and Erin patted his shoulder. She turned and beamed at Imenet.

“Want to play another game?”

“I should enjoy that very much. Please.”

They began to play. Ryoka stood watching the game. To be honest, she didn’t watch the game so much as Regrika’s expression. The Gnoll, or rather, Venitra, was watching the game with something like horror in her eyes. Because Erin won. She played Imenet twice more, lost one game, won one—it didn’t matter that she didn’t win everything. When she beat Az’kerash, Ryoka saw part of Venitra failing to comprehend.

“That’s right. Your master isn’t flawless. Sucks, don’t it?”

Ryoka muttered to Regrika after the game was over. The Gnoll turned. There was pure fury in her eyes. She gripped Ryoka’s hand and squeezed. Just for a moment.

Erin Solstice was having a good day. It seemed like a lot of days were good days recently, but today was excellent. She’d made a cake. She had important visitors, and she got to meet Xrn, who was really cool! And best of all—she got to play chess.

Why couldn’t all days be like this? Erin sighed as she pushed herself back from the game and shook Imenet’s hand. The purple-scaled Drake smiled at her, his grip soft and light.

“You are a true master of this game. I am honored to play you and intrigued. Where did you obtain this level of skill?”

“Practice! Years of practice?”

Erin laughed until she remembered that chess had only been invented recently. She coughed.

“I play all the time. I’d love to play you again sometime if you’re up for it.”

“I believe I am.”

The Drake smiled slightly and turned away. Erin beamed, and then noticed Ryoka heading for the doors.

“Hey Ryoka, are you going out?”

“I—I’m going for a run.”

Ryoka’s hands were shoved deep in her pockets. She stomped towards the doors quickly, seeming to shield her right side. Erin frowned.

“At night? It’s dangerous—”

“Yeah. I’ll be back in a bit. I’ll see you—later, Erin. Have a good night.”

She left. Erin sighed, but let her moody friend go. She turned and saw Regrika was smiling and dining with all the Gnolls who loved her so much. She frowned as she saw the Gnoll bite with relish into a bit of her beef casserole. Erin stopped Lyonette as she went about the tables. She, Drassi, and Ishkr had been on their feet all night and looked beat. Erin made a note to pay them extra for tonight.

“Hey Lyonette, Regrika and that Imenet guy like their food, right? Have they asked for anything changed or complained about the taste?”

Lyonette blinked at Erin and shook her head.

“No, they said they liked it. Why? Is something wrong?”

“It’s just a feeling. Eh, whatever.”

Erin shook off the odd sensation in her head and grinned.

“A Named Adventurer *and* a Gnoll party! We’re raking in the dough tonight!”

“Raking? I thought you kneaded dough. Or is that some advanced form of cooking I don’t know about?”

“No, it’s this expression see. I—you know what, forget it.”

Erin deflated slightly. She waved the comment off and then looked around. She spotted Brunkr sitting alone at a table and wandered over.

“Brunkr! Aren’t you going to go have fun with the others? This party’s about you, right?”

The Gnoll grinned down at Erin, looking slightly drunk and very happy.

“It is good of you to say, yes? But I know this is for my Aunt, and for Ryoka as much as anything. My class is wonderful, but it is not *all* of this party. And Regrika Blackpaw’s presence honors us far more than my class.”

“Yeah, but your class is still cool! [Knight]! Wow! How did you get it?”

Brunkr’s eyes flicked from Erin to something over her shoulder. He smiled.

“I cannot say. It is not my secret to give, yes?”

“Aw. Really? Well, maybe you could share it with Yvlon? She wants to be a [Knight] too, you know.”

“She does? Hrm.”

Brunkr glanced with interest over at Yvlon, who was sitting at a table and still talking about the Crelers they’d killed with the other Gold-rank adventurers. He smiled a bit.

“Perhaps I will talk with her or...others about such a thing. But my class was a gift, truly. I am unsure of what I will do with my new class, but perhaps such a life might be worth doing after all.”

Erin frowned.

“Do what? Be an adventurer? I hope you’re not going down into the dungeon!”

Brunkr shook his head instantly.

“Of course not. I am no fool, yes? I owe too much to you, my aunt, and...and to Lyonette to risk my life so easily. But when I see adventurers

like Regrika or—or your friends, I remember that I too wish to become more than I am. The Horns of Hammerad—”

Erin’s eyes widened.

“Do you want to...?”

She glanced at her friends. Brunkr looked embarrassed and shook his head.

“I am no doubt rusty. And I have just recovered. A single level in a class is—”

“I could ask! I’m sure they’d be happy to have you!”

“No, no. I must practice first. There are other Gnolls I can join up with. I will—no, please Erin. This is not the time to talk of such things. I did not mean to bring it up. I wished to speak with you in private, if I am honest.”

“Me? About what?”

Brunkr paused. He rested his butt on the table where he and Erin were talking, and looked around her lively inn. His eyes lingered on Lyonette, and then on Mrsha as she curled up into a ball by the fireplace. A large bee crawled onto her head, fanning its wings by the flames.

“It is a strange thing, to believe you know someone and not know them at all.”

He looked at Erin, and nodded at her.

“You saved my arm.”

“Aw, that was—”

“Everything to me. I do not mistake it. You saved my arm, Erin Solstice. For that I cannot be more grateful. And I am more humbled, yes, to know how badly I misjudged you.”

Erin fell silent. She didn’t know what to say to that. She needed to say nothing, as it turned out. Brunkr stared at her, and then out a window at the snow, reflectively. He spoke quietly.

“I did not know you. I thought you were an enemy, a fool at first. I was consumed by an image of you that was wrong. Entirely wrong. When I realized how ignorant I was, I felt as though I had lost my legs, my balance,

and was falling. The world changed for me. My arm—I am sorry for all I said when you first came to me. Yes. I am sorry, and grateful we met.”

He smiled at Erin, looking a bit embarrassed. Brunkr turned his head away quickly and Erin grinned in delight. Gnoll faces were too furry to see, but she was sure, absolutely sure that he was blushing.

“You’re so nice. Aw. You’re making me blush.”

“I just wished to say thank you, Erin. Thank you. It is not often enough that we give honest thanks for what is done, yes? I want to say that. So you know what I do from now is thanks to you.”

He reached out and offered Erin a hand. His right hand. She shook it and beamed at him.

“Want more cake?”

Brunkr paused. He glanced around the room and lowered his voice.

“You have more?”

She grinned and nodded. Brunkr’s tail began to wag and he followed her into the kitchen. It was just some extras, but he ate them with delight. Erin watched, happy and content.

A good day.

It seems this gathering has ended. Venitra, Ijvani, attend to my words.

The two undead had never been more relieved to hear their master’s words. They quickly bade farewell and left the inn. It was dark and close to midnight as the Gnolls and other partygoers finally began to leave. The two undead walked towards Liscor in the snow, listening to their master’s words.

Venitra, you have disappointed me. I ordered you not to harm Ryoka Griffin.

“Master, I only—”

Silence. You are failing me.

There could be no worse words. Venitra hung her head in silence. Ijvani waited, terrified she might hear the same.

And yet, it seems your failures have brought me an interesting conundrum and information about the rest of the world. For that alone, I will forgive you.

Both undead raised their heads hesitantly. They dared to hope. Az’kerash was silent, and then he spoke authoritatively, calmly.

Here are your instructions for now. Observe. Keep your true identities hidden. Do not harm Ryoka Griffin. That is an order, Venitra. And learn more about her relationship with the Antinium—as well as the Drakes. As for this inn, inquire about it and the magical door as well. I sensed it—it is an enchantment of peculiar power which does not belong in this place. Neither does that chessboard, but this Erin Solstice...ah. Inquire, that is all. I will contact you again tomorrow.

Both Venitra and Ijvani nodded. They felt Az’kerash’s presence in their minds, reassuring them, filling them, and then he was gone. In the bleak world that followed, both recalled their failures.

“He lost a game of chess. Twice.”

Venitra stopped in the snow. She turned to Ijvani and blurted out the thing both had been obsessing over for the entire night. Ijvani nodded.

“He beat the [Innkeeper] in the end, though.”

“But he lost. Our master. She—defeated him.”

“It was a game, Venitra.”

“Yes. And he lost it.”

Ijvani looked down at the ground. Venitra stared back towards the inn. She shook silently. Her master had lost a game. Her master.

Lost.

A.

Game.

And what had Ryoka Griffin said? He was not perfect? Something broke inside of Venitra. She stared at the Gnolls leaving the inn, laughing, talking. She stared at one as he left alone, bidding farewell to his aunt.

Brunkr was walking down the streets of Liscor, gently swaying, licking around his face for more of the sweet frosting he’d eaten, when he heard and smelled someone coming up behind him. He turned, and immediately bowed his head slightly. Regrika Blackpaw strode towards him.

She was his hero. Brunkr wondered if he should say something or just get out of the way, but it was Regrika who spoke to him.

“Do you have time to talk?”

“Of course!”

Brunkr’s ears perked up. He eagerly fell into step besides Regrika, wondering what she could want to talk about. She led him down a side path, down alleyways that were devoid of criminals, but still not places Brunkr would normally walk. He supposed Regrika feared no routes at all.

“I am told this party at the inn today was for you, young Brunkr. That is...good, yes? You must have had a good relationship with the innkeeper to have it there.”

The young Gnoll blushed. She knew about his class? He spoke up.

“Yes, Honored Regrika. We had it there because my Aunt, Krshia Silverfang, is a friend of the owner. I am...indebted to her as well.”

“Indeed?”

Regrika’s face was shadowed. The clouds were dark and the sky was dark, but it was warming, Brunkr felt. He nodded.

“She saved my arm, my life as a warrior. I owe her—and Lyonette much. I would help them in any way I could, yes.”

“She helped you. Then she cares for you. You are a person that matters to Erin Solstice.”

“I—hope so.”

Brunkr hesitated. He wished he could be someone like that. But Erin had so many friends. Many people helped her. He was just one. A small, nonentity compared to someone like Zel Shivertail, or even Relc. Krshia had told Brunkr about the famous Gecko and his prowess during war. Relc was a hero. Brunkr was just a child. But he wanted to be like Regrika.

“I would do much for Erin Solstice. I hope that in time she will regard me with a part of the esteem I hold for her.”

That was all he could manage after a few seconds of thought. Regrika nodded abruptly.

“That will do. Yes, that is...appropriate.”

She halted in the street in front of Brunkr. He paused uncertainly. Regrika turned to Brunkr and he backed up a step unconsciously. She was breathing heavily. Brunkr’s smile faded.

“Honored Regrika? Is everything alright?”

The Gnoll stared at him. Then her body changed. The Gnoll with black fur vanished. In her place, a giant made of bone stood, a woman carved of ivory. Brunkr backed up, eyes wide. He reached for a sword he didn’t have. He turned to run—

Venitra twisted his neck around with a *snap*.

Brunkr's body jerked once. She held him up and stabbed her hand through his chest, breaking bone and skin. She dropped the Gnoll's lifeless body. Brunkr's open ribcage stared up at the cloudy night.

He lay on the empty street, motionless. Venitra stood over him, shaking. She struck the lifeless body. Then she threw it against a wall.

There was no voice in the silent street, only the crunch of heavy footsteps in the snow. Venitra picked Brunkr up and threw him again. He flew across the street and landed in a heap. Then Venitra gave vent to her fury. She stomped on the ground, pounded the walls, and kicked the motionless corpse, raging silently in the cold.

Like a child.

When she was done, Ijvani appeared in the shadows behind her. The black skeleton stared up at the woman made of white bone and at the body at her feet.

"You did not need to do that."

She spoke cautiously and backed up as Venitra stared at her. There was blood on her body. Venitra spoke, her voice icy calm.

"No one disgraces our master."

She paused, and Ijvani nodded slowly in agreement. She looked at the body and then at Venitra.

"All done?"

"Yes."

"In that case, I will clean up. We must find a spot to place the body. I doubt hiding it would be the correct move. Hmm. You may have to kill some other Gnolls. Adventurers."

Venitra smiled.

"Gladly."

She strode past Ijvani. The skeleton mage stared at Brunkr's body. She sighed and reached for him.

"Temper. Why is she the master's favorite?"

Brunkr did not reply.

The next day, Brunkr's body was found in Liscor's dungeon, at the bottom of the crevasse, surrounded by a group of Gnolls, a known Silver-rank team and a few other Bronze-rank Gnolls who'd disappeared the previous night as well. Their bodies bore wounds consistent with a monster attack.

They were discovered as the sun was beginning to set in the sky.

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4.29

“I think we’re done here.”

“Really? But I thought—”

“Is that my tower? It is not as tall as I requested, Pawn.”

“You wanted a tower that was structurally unfeasible, Bird.”

“Yes. So?”

“This is as high as we deemed it necessary. You can shoot birds in it, and Erin—”

“I see a third floor, and I also see my inn’s bigger on the side. Right. And I have two new outhouses.”

“Yes. Are you unhappy with any of the work?”

“No, not unhappy. It’s just...my only question is...why’d you put the tower on one end of the inn?”

Erin stared up at the watchtower from her position in the snow outside. It was wet and cold, but warmer than yesterday. The sun was out and she had an unparalleled view of her new inn. And she was grateful, she really was.

Her inn was now *big*. Bigger, that was. It had been big. Now it was grand. It had a ground floor a third again as large, two new rooms on the second floor and an entire new third floor! And a tower. And while she was very grateful to the Antinium for all their tireless hard work, she had to question the tower.

It looked like a proper watch tower, sure enough. It had an open roof with enough space for someone to pace about on top. It would allow a bird-obsessed hunter to both keep a lookout and hunt birds in his spare time. It even had gutters which were angled so that if it rained, the water wouldn’t run down the stairs into the rest of the inn.

It was great. And Erin was sure that height aside, Bird loved it. It was just that the watch tower wasn’t placed symmetrically in the center of the

inn. Rather, it was on the ‘back’, against the far wall from the front door. It made the inn look lopsided. That was Erin’s impression, though.

Pawn and Bird regarded the watch tower and looked at each other. They clearly couldn’t see the problem.

“Is there an issue with the placement of the tower, Erin? I thought it was quite appropriate.”

Erin smiled at Pawn’s worried face. She hadn’t seen enough of him lately, and she didn’t want to distress him, especially since it wasn’t that big a deal. It was just that every symmetrical instinct Erin had was crying out against this travesty.

“No, I mean, if it works, it works, right? And you put it over Bird’s room. I get that. But I just assumed it would be in the center, for uh, visibility, you know?”

Pawn nodded thoughtfully.

“A worthy idea. However, I elected to place the tower on that side in case you wanted another tower built in the future.”

“Another tower?”

“Yes. Perhaps one that is enchanted to throw lightning or hurl spells like the walls of Drake cities. Or if you wished to construct a fourth floor. Or mount a ballista on top. I am not aware of the methods with which to construct one, but the Antinium have our own plans for catapults we could share.”

“A ballista.”

The Antinium Worker realized he’d lost Erin. He looked over at Bird. The other Antinium clutched his new bow to his chest and nodded a few times.

“I could kill many birds with one. That is a good idea, Pawn.”

Erin coughed a few times.

“Yeah. A good idea. Well...good work! I think that’s all my questions answered. Anyone—anyone want something to drink? It’s on me. That means it’s free, you two.”

Pawn and Bird exchanged a glance. Pawn looked back at Erin. Bird kept staring.

“We would be delighted to have a drink, Erin. But I am afraid I must return to my Hive soon. Hm. Perhaps you could sell me a keg? Sharing a drink with my unit is a good idea.”

“Sounds good!”

Erin beamed. Pawn glanced back at Bird. He was still staring at Pawn.

“Bird, have I done something to offend you?”

“I wish to hunt birds. Are you trying to prevent me from sitting in my tower now, Pawn?”

“No, Bird. You are free to sit in your new tower.”

“You say that, but social obligations force me to drink with you. You explained this to me last week. This is a trap. I do not wish to drink but my status as ‘friend’ with you and Miss Erin prohibits me from refusing.”

Erin started to laugh and covered it. Pawn opened his mandibles and sighed.

“Bird, that is not...do I need to explain this to you again?”

“Yes.”

“I’ll leave you two to it! Pawn, come inside when you want to. Bird, you can sit in your tower if you want? I’ll tell Lyonette to send up a drink for you!”

The two Antinium watched Erin walk into her refurbished inn. Bird waved as Erin shut the door and then turned to Pawn.

“That was a considerate statement. Why could you not have made a similar statement to begin with?”

“I didn’t say anything about you having to drink with me, Bird.”

“You said ‘we’. We implies multiple people, which in turn implies me. You said it despite my use of a meaningful stare you should have correctly interpreted. This is very hurtful, Pawn. I wish to sit in my tower and you have disregarded my feelings.”

Pawn glared at Bird.

“Look here, Bird. This is a stupid and pointless argument we are having. Each second we have it is a second I don’t spend drinking with Erin and you spend outside, rather than in your tower! Do I have to explain how free will and social dynamics work again?”

“...Maybe. Yes.”

Erin’s new inn smelled like sawdust, fresh wood, and varnish. She could have done without the last bit, but at least it wasn’t tacky to the touch. The Antinium used a very quick-drying form of resin that was one of the reasons why they’d cornered the construction market in Liscor.

“Erin!”

Lyonette turned to Erin and smiled. She had food out and was serving drinks to the Workers and Soldiers who’d just finished their work. They were pretty much the only customers in the inn right now; breakfast had passed and it was before the lunch rush.

It was a good morning. Erin took another deep breath, and then looked around for Mrsha. She was nowhere on the bottom floor of the inn. Erin had a sense Mrsha was probably scampering about upstairs, probably with Apista clinging to her head.

“Hey Lyonette, that new bee of yours really likes Mrsha, doesn’t she? She’s always crawling on top of Mrsha’s head. Is that uh, safe?”

“Apista? I think so! I have a connection with her and she never feels violent when she’s around Mrsha. I don’t think she’d sting anyone anyways, Erin. I’m more worried Mrsha will squish her, to be honest.”

“Right. Right. Pawn’s coming in for a drink in a bit and he might want to buy a keg. Bird’s probably going to sit in his new tower. Could you bring him a mug of something when you get a chance?”

“Sure! Pawn’s buying a whole keg? Really?”

“He’ll probably bring it back to his Hive. Hey, have you seen Ryoka? I didn’t see her at breakfast this morning.”

Lyonette frowned as she offered a Soldier a mug. The Antinium cautiously took it, staring at the Human girl. He had yellow splatters of paint all across his chest.

“Oh. She said she wasn’t hungry so she grabbed a roll and left. I haven’t seen her since.”

“Figures. She’s been grumpy and weird again, lately. I don’t know why.”

Erin crossed her arms and frowned. She hadn’t gotten a chance to talk with Ryoka, but she distinctly remembered Ryoka’s odd looks last night. Was she really planning on scouting the Goblin Lord’s army like everyone was saying? And why had Ivolethe chased her away? Erin hoped that Ryoka wasn’t doing stupid stuff again.

Struck by a thought, Erin turned back to Lyonette.

“You’re feeling okay, right Lyon? If you’re tired, let me know and I can take over. I gave Ishkr and Drassi time off because yesterday was so busy. If you need a break...”

“I’m good! Serving the Antinium is easy since they don’t cause trouble, and no one else is coming in yet. If you give me a hand at lunch, I think we’ll be set!”

Lyonette smiled at Erin and Erin gave her a thumbs up in reply. She settled down at a table after pouring a drink for Pawn and herself. She had a nice variety of alcohol now thanks to her thirsty guests, but she still wished she could have some cool fruit juice from time to time. Maybe she could squeeze it herself? But it was so *expensive*...

Erin frowned as she sipped from her mug. She glanced up as the door opened and waved.

“Pawn! Oh—”

It wasn’t Pawn. Krshia entered the room, pausing to wipe her wet and snowy feet on the doormat. The Gnoll sniffed, and then spotted Erin.

“Erin. It is good to see you today, yes? I do not wish to bother you so early, but—have you seen Brunkr today?”

“I’m not bothered! Come and have a seat! Pawn’s going to join me for a drink. You want one?”

“Thank you, but no. I am looking for my nephew. You have not seen him yet?”

Krshia came over to the table. Erin frowned.

“I haven’t seen Brunkr since the party last night. Why?”

“He did not return home last night. I assumed he found somewhere else to sleep or found company—he has done so before. But no one I have spoken to remembers seeing him at another inn, or anywhere else in the city afterwards.”

Erin frowned as she sipped from her mug. She sat up a bit straighter in her chair.

“That *is* weird. I remember that Brunkr was pretty drunk last night. I don’t think he would have kept drinking. Maybe he fell asleep in a tavern or something?”

Krshia bared her teeth, although it wasn’t a smile.

“That was my first guess. But I have not spotted him or smelled him—and I assume he would be awake by now unless he truly drank too much. If he is not here, I will ask a few of the young ones to go hunting for him in the city. Thank you, Erin.”

“No problem. And tell Brunkr that I’ll talk to him about joining the Horns of Hammerad later, okay? They’re out right now. I think they’re in Celum—something about getting a new gauntlet for Yvlon’s arm? Anyways. Good luck finding him!”

Krshia nodded. She stepped out of the inn at the same time Pawn and Bird walked in. Erin thought no more of it, and she waved Pawn over. Bird went upstairs, and Lyonette followed him with a mug.

Pawn sat with Erin and introduced her to Yellow Splatters, one of the Antinium Soldiers who was apparently important. More so than the others, for some reason. Pawn refused to elaborate and told Erin it was a secret for now. Obviously, Yellow Splatters didn’t say anything.

They talked, and then the Antinium left in a single mass. After paying, of course. They always paid. A ‘tab’ was a foreign concept to them. Erin sat and daydreamed about catapults. After a while, Mrsha slunk into the room with Apista on her head. The bee flew off to bask next to the fire, which was a relief to Erin since Mrsha had curled up on her lap. Lyonette came down and began bringing dishes to the kitchen for Ishkr to wash later.

Lunch arrived too quickly, with a rush of visitors, some from Liscor, but most from Celum. Octavia came in too, hungry because she’d forgotten to eat since yesterday. She told Erin her sales of matches were through the roof, and showed her some more of the penicillin-type mold she’d grown. Erin made her wash her hands before eating.

Krshia came back as Erin and Lyonette were serving guests today’s special—grilled cheese sandwiches. Some had ham inside for extra niceness.

“Krshia! Hey, have you found him yet? Brunkr?”

“No, Erin. We have not. And now others are looking. I had thought he might have...it is nothing. I am sorry to bother you when you are busy, no.”

The Gnoll looked around the inn and shook her head. Erin frowned and signaled to Lyonette to take over for a moment.

“Do you want me to go look for him? I have time. We’re not that busy.”

“No, I—think we will be fine. It is just odd. We have not picked up a fresh scent of Brunkr. His trail vanishes. I hoped to get a fresher smell of him here. But it is faint here, too.”

Erin nodded. She felt a flash of—she ignored it.

“Well, okay. Let me know when you find him, alright?”

Krshia nodded. She left without a word. Erin got back to work. She felt a bit uneasy, now. But it was just a feeling. She told herself that as she served lunch, and then began to tidy up. Because she no longer felt like relaxing, she went into the kitchen and washed some dishes.

The door opened a third time as the sun was beginning to set in the sky. Erin knew Lyonette was upstairs and Mrsha was napping with her. Hands covered in sudsy water, she poked her head out of the kitchen. Krshia was standing in the doorway.

“Hey. Did you find—”

The words caught in Erin’s throat. Across the room, Krshia looked at her. Just looked. The Gnoll’s fur was wet with melted snow and sweat. Her chest rose and fell quickly, as if she’d just been running. And her eyes. Her eyes were too bright.

There was nothing supernatural about what Erin understood in that moment. It had nothing to do with magic or fate, and everything to do with the look on Krshia’s face.

Erin knew. But she pretended she didn’t. She told herself she didn’t.

“Did—did you find him? Brunkr?”

She smiled, forcing her lips to move as she walked out of the kitchen. A bit of soapy water dripped onto the floor. Krshia stared at the droplets on the floorboards, and then at Erin. Her voice was very distant.

“He is dead.”

“What?”

Erin was still smiling in that moment. She didn’t register what Krshia had said. She didn’t want to. Her heart began to beat faster.

“Krshia?”

The Gnoll looked at Erin. She had tears in her eyes.

“He is dead. My nephew, Brunkr. He is dead.”

There was a hole in the world. Erin fell through. She walked out from behind the counter as Krshia went on.

“They found him in the dungeon. In—at the bottom of the crevasse. His body and eight others. A team of Silver-rank Gnolls and—all dead. They were torn apart by some kind of monster, it seems.”

Erin felt the ground break under her. The day shattered. There was a hole in the world and Erin felt herself falling. Krshia collapsed into a chair and Erin sat on the floor. She didn’t believe it. She couldn’t believe it.

“Where is he now?”

There was a hole in the world. A dark, deep pit. Brunkr was lying there. They brought him out of the dungeon with magic and ropes. When she saw

his body, Erin believed. She ran back to the inn to tell Lyonette to bring Mrsha away, far away. But it was too late. Mrsha smelled him. And she knew.

The city was filled with howling. The sun shone and melted the snow. Erin sat in the kitchen of her inn and wept.

And then Ryoka found Ishkr standing outside the inn. He was there for his evening shift. He hadn't heard until the howling began. He was crying in the melting snow when she asked him what was wrong. He turned to her, and she saw it in his eyes. And she knew too.

"I'm going to kill her."

Ryoka choked on the words. She ran, gasping in the cold air, tripped, fell. The snow was wet. Melting. Ryoka pushed herself up. She stood in the middle of Liscor's rolling hills and valleys. In the middle of nowhere.

The snow had melted into ice in places. Part of the crust had cut Ryoka's hands and arms as she fell. The blood and water mixed and dripped into the white snow, staining it. Ryoka looked down at her hands.

"I should have done it last night. I'll kill her. I'll—"

She choked on the words. There were tears in her eyes. Ryoka took a shaking breath, and then choked again. She coughed and bent over in the snow. Her lungs were burning. Her heart hurt.

And it was filled with rage. Ryoka felt at her belt. She grabbed a large bag of flour and the igniter.

"I'll blow her up. I—I can do it. I'll lure her into a trap or—or—"

"And do what? Die? You cannot harm her. You know that."

Someone floated down beside Ryoka. Ivolethe stared at her Human friend, melancholy in her eyes. Ryoka turned to Ivolethe and half shouted,

half screamed at her. The sound caught in her throat and she doubled over. She retched, and nothing came up. She hadn't eaten since last night, really.

"I can't let her get away. She killed—she—she did it to hurt me! I know she did!"

"Perhaps. But you know she did it because she could. Because you could not stop her. That is the truth."

The Frost Faerie landed on Ryoka's shoulder. She stared at Ryoka, not unsympathetically. Her words drove needles into the young woman's skin. Ryoka grabbed her head with her hands.

"I know! I know. I can't do a thing. I can only—"

She bit her lip, hard enough to break the skin. She could only tell someone like Zel or Ilvriss that Az'kerash's servants were here. Then she would die. The [Word of Death] spell was on her, and if that failed, Venitra was sure to kill her.

But she had to do it. She had to do something. Brunkr was dead. Because of her. Because she had failed to do anything. Because she had been afraid.

Ryoka had hated before. She had hated her father, her teachers, the fake people at school and the entire world. She thought she knew hate. Only now, in this moment did she realize that she had never really hated anything before.

Venitra. Ryoka clenched her jaw so tightly her teeth ground together and nearly cracked. She hated only one person as much as Venitra. And that was the Goblin Lord.

Hate. She stood in the snow. Winter was ending. Ryoka looked to Ivolethe, resting on her shoulder.

"I don't know what to do. Ivolethe. Tell me. What should I do?"

Ivolethe looked back into Ryoka's eyes. She was melting. Her body was crystal and liquid, ice and fading perfection. When she spoke, she pointed up towards the open, blue sky.

“Remember this, Ryoka Griffin: when you run, the wind knows. The wind is a thing. A thing that thinks, like trees do, or rocks. The earth is not alive, but neither is it *dead*. Remember that. Step as if you mean to walk into the sky. That is how faeries fly.”

Ryoka stared at her. Ivolethe flew off her shoulder as Ryoka lashed out. She circled Ryoka’s head, speaking calmly.

“What? Do you expect me to grieve with you? I did not know this Brunkr. I mourn, but he was not my friend. Do you wish me to tell you it will be alright? I will not lie. And I will not dictate your fate. I will not. I cannot.”

Her words were like ice. Painful, piercing, but also clear and true. Ryoka’s shoulder slumped.

“I know. But I can’t—”

She hesitated, afraid to give voice to her feelings. Ryoka stood in the snow as it melted onto her boots and heard a shout.

“Hey! You! Yeah, you, Runner Girl! I remember you!”

She and Ivolethe turned. Running towards them through the snow was a green blur. Ryoka recognized Relc and raised a hand as he skidded to a stop, spraying snow towards her. He grinned at Ryoka, showing her two rows of pointed teeth.

“I just remembered! You’re *that* Runner, aren’t you? The one I nearly caught way back when! ”

Ryoka stared at him. Relc laughed.

“Don’t you remember? You were running down the north road and I was on patrol. I ran after you and I *nearly* had you, but then you got away! We should have a rematch! All those bastards at the barracks were saying I was slow! *Me!*”

It felt wrong for Relc to be here, laughing and upbeat. Ryoka could barely remember the incident he was describing. What was it? When she'd—yes, right after Pisces had healed her legs. She'd run back towards Celum and she remembered an angry Drake in armor chasing her.

“You were that [Guardsmen]?”

“Sure was! I can't believe it's you! Small world, huh?”

Ryoka nodded. Then she stared at Relc.

“So what?”

He paused.

“Excuse me?”

Sorrow and helplessness became anger. Ryoka stared at Relc.

“Who cares how fast you are?”

The Drake looked insulted.

“I do. I want to race you again, to prove I'm faster. Not here—there are no witnesses. Back at Liscor. We'll clear some snow or maybe run around the city. Then I'll prove I'm the fastest!”

“Who cares? You lost! It doesn't matter!”

Ryoka turned away, trying to resist the urge to punch Relc and get arrested or have her nose broken. The Drake danced around her, looking indignant.

“I didn't lose! I mean, it wasn't a fair race! I was in armor and I had my spear! Do you know how heavy chainmail is?”

“Not very. You can still run with it on.”

Relc opened his mouth and his tail twitched guiltily.

“Well, yeah. Right. But it's still heavy if you're trying to sprint in it! And I had too much to eat that day. You had a head start by the time I started chasing you—and uh, I had to get up to speed! If I'd have felt like it, I would have totally caught you in the next minute. But I'm a responsible guardsman so I had to get back to my patrol.”

“Right.”

“I’m telling the truth! Race me again and—”

“Oh shut *up!*”

Ryoka turned and shouted at Relc. He blinked. Ryoka raised her voice, too angry to care about the tears in her eyes.

“Don’t you have any decency for god’s sake? Someone just died, or haven’t you heard? I don’t want to race you, so piss off and *leave me alone!*”

She was breathing heavily. She turned and wiped at her face with a sleeve. When Relc spoke next, it was more quietly.

“I know. I didn’t know you knew the guy, though.”

“I didn’t. Not really. Not at all. But—”

She wanted to say it was her fault. And she knew she couldn’t. Relc shrugged his massive shoulders. He sounded genuinely contrite.

“Sorry about that. I uh, thought it wouldn’t bother you since you’re Human and he was—it sucks. I get that. But I wasn’t friends with the guy. And I’ve seen buddies die before. Too many. If I got bogged down every time it happened I wouldn’t be able to do my job.”

“What, you mean your job is coming out here and harassing me?”

Ryoka turned and glared. Relc smiled and pulled something out of his belt pouch.

“Not really. That was just for fun. See, I am here to talk to you about that Brunkr guy.”

“Why?”

“Oh...Klb has a hunch, and all the Gnolls are really upset about it. So Captain Z ordered us to look into it.”

Relc tossed a clear crystal—it looked like quartz—up and down in his palm. He spoke as he glanced back towards the city and then at Ryoka. The air of reckless energy around him was gone. He was still animated, but now he was serious. When she saw that, Ryoka calmed down a little.

“Here’s the thing about the Brunkr guy. We found him in the dungeon, at the bottom of that rift. You heard? Right. They died right at the bottom,

right near the ropes. When Klb heard that, he got a bit suspicious. I mean, that Brunkr guy was a good [Warrior] by all accounts. So we decided to do some investigating.”

Ryoka’s heart began to beat faster.

“Investigating? Why?”

“I dunno. It’s a hunch.”

Relc shrugged.

“It could be it was all an accident and some damn monsters killed the Gnolls. Or it might not be. Might’ve been a fight that ended badly and got covered up. Maybe Brunkr went down on a dare. Or maybe the other adventurers dragged him with them. Maybe it was just him and the Gnolls being stupid. But Erin swears he wouldn’t have gone down there and Klb and I believe her. So we’re doing an investigation.”

“And you came to find me.”

“That’s right. It’s nothing personal, but you were at that party last night, right? I was there—didn’t see you talking to Brunkr, but Klb says we have to cover all angles. So I have this.”

He showed the bit of quartz to Ryoka. She stared at it. It was a truth stone. She looked at Relc, dread in her stomach.

“What...do you want me to say?”

The [Guardsmen]’s eyes focused on her. He was still smiling, but his eyes were serious and his posture—it was just a little tense.

“Tell me you didn’t do it.”

Ryoka stared at the gem in Relc’s hands. The Drake looked down at her. There was no accusation in his eyes. But he was waiting. Ryoka opened her mouth and spoke. Slowly.

“I didn’t do it.”

The gem flashed. Ryoka stared at it. Part of her expected it to show her lie. But it glowed bright blue. A false color. A liar’s color.

“Well, that settles that! I told Klb it was pointless, but he insisted. He even tested Erin. And the Mrsha kid! Isn’t he crazy?”

Relc tucked the stone into his belt pouch, laughing. Ryoka stared at him. Laughter was the furthest thing from her mind, but then she realized something terrible.

“He’s testing everyone from the party?”

The Drake nodded.

“Yep! Got them to come back to the inn and everything. I think it’s easier there—lots of booze so they can drink until they drop, y’know?”

They were testing everyone. Ryoka’s pulse raced. She turned back to the inn.

“I have to get back there.”

“What? Wait? What’s the rush? Oh! This is a race! Alright! Let’s do this!”

Relc shouted with glee and raced after Ryoka through the snow.

Erin sat in her inn, numb, quiet. She heard people talking, heard tears, listened to Mrsha howling and Krshia and Lyonette trying to comfort her. She could hear Krshia’s voice breaking. Erin listened to tears.

She did not cry. She couldn’t. A part of her was curled up in mourning, but it was only a part. The rest felt...numb. Some part of Erin was still awake in her grief. It whispered to her. It spoke.

I have been here before.

She had felt this very feeling. Erin could remember it, when Klbkch died. When the Horns of Hammerad were pronounced dead. When she killed the Goblin Chieftain. She had been here before. Only this time it was different.

This time part of her called out for vengeance. Brunkr’s death had come as a shock to all the Gnolls, to Erin, to Lyonette, to everyone at the party. It seemingly had no reason, and Erin had no idea why it had happened. But she did know one thing.

It was no accident.

Her head turned as the door slammed open. Relc surged into the room, beaming, and deflated as he saw the mood. He coughed, and held the door open. Half a minute later Ryoka stumbled through the door, breathing heavily.

All eyes turned to her and Relc as they walked into the room. Ryoka sat down heavily at a table, looking around. Relc edged over to where Klbkch was interviewing a group of three Gnolls. He nudged the Antinium. When Klbkch turned around Relc whispered loudly.

“I won.”

Erin had no idea what that was about. Neither did she care. She only had eyes for Klbkch. The Antinium turned back to the Gnolls without a word and asked them a question. Each replied. The stone in Klbkch’s hands glowed white each time they responded. He moved on.

They were all there, all the people who’d been here last night. Klbkch, the blue Antinium named Xrn who’d eaten so much, the Horns of Hammerad, Griffon Hunt, the Halfseekers, Zel and the Wall Lord...and the Gnolls.

They were eating. Quietly, some while crying. Others just drank, but Lyonette, Drassi, and Ishkr were serving food from Erin’s kitchen, hot and fresh as the moment it had been cooked.

It felt wrong to Erin. But the Gnolls were grieving as they ate. They had to—it was evening and many hadn’t had lunch or breakfast before they found out. And they were a different people. They ate and mourned Brunkr in their own way.

“Miss Blackpaw, it is your turn now.”

Erin’s head turned. She saw Ryoka look up at her table. Klbkch calmly walked over to the huge Gnoll. Like the others, Regrika was eating. She pushed back her plate and turned to face Klbkch.

“I am ready.”

Was it just convenience or another reason that had made Klbkch ask everyone to return to the inn? Erin watched as Klbkch consulted a bit of parchment he was holding.

“Regrika Blackpaw, you were seen talking to Brunkr last night, before leaving the party. You did not have a long conversation and it was within sight of other guests. I have one question for you. Did you meet, speak with, or interact in any other way with Brunkr Silverfang after leaving the party?”

The room was silent. It had grown silent each time Klbkch asked a question. Erin saw Ulrien shift casually in his seat. It was just a thought. Of course it wasn't Regrika Blackpaw who'd murdered Brunkr, if that was what had happened. But she could see the thoughts running through the Gold-rank adventurer's minds. It wasn't, but if it was...

The Named Adventurer with black fur did not look concerned by Klbkch's question. She smiled as he held the crystal in front of her. Her smile was as innocent as could be. It was a child's smile.

“I did not meet with Brunkr, no. I regret to say that I did not see him after the party, and missed his presence at the end of it. I am afraid that is all I know, Senior Guardsman.”

Everyone stared at the truth gem. It flashed white. Klbkch nodded. Ryoka stared at the gem. Her face was pale. Erin kept staring at Regrika's face.

Klbkch consulted the gem and nodded.

“Thank you, Miss Blackpaw. I will interview Imenet Southwing next. Mister Southwing, last night you were seen...”

Prompted by some instinct, Erin got up and walked over to where Ryoka was sitting. The other young woman was sweaty and looked—disturbed. She caught Relc as he was passing.

“Hey, why is the other gem flashing white?”

Relc made a face.

“Eh. Truth gems. They're enchanted by different mages. Some flash white when the answer's true, others blue, green...it's a pain in the tail. I once had a gem where it would flash red if you were telling the truth and brown if you were lying. Who does that?”

Ryoka didn't reply. She sat back in her chair, staring at Regrika's back. Erin frowned.

“Ryoka? Are you okay?”

The other girl started and looked at Erin. Imenet was done being interviewed, and Klbkch was consulting his list. She shook her head.

“I—can’t stay here. I shouldn’t have come back. Stupid. I should have known—”

She got up abruptly. Erin caught at her arm.

“Ryoka. I want to talk. Can you speak with me upstairs?”

She felt like there was a hole in her chest, but the dreadful certainty in her gut was moving her. Someone killed Brunkr. She wanted Ryoka’s help, but the Asian girl shook her head.

“I really can’t. I’m sorry, Erin.”

“Ryoka, I *need*—”

“I said no!”

Ryoka snapped. Heads turned. Erin let go of Ryoka’s arm. She had never been angrier with her friend than at this moment.

“Fine. Go.”

She saw Ryoka turn guiltily to her, but she still left. Erin watched the door swing shut. Klbkch looked up from his notes.

“I believe that is everyone. It seems there is no indication that Brunkr’s death was a result, however indirectly, of the actions of anyone within this building.”

A gentle sigh ran through the room, and Mrsha howled again upstairs. Erin stared at Klbkch as he went to consult with Relc. From their postures, she knew they were wrapping things up. They’d already talked to friends of the other deceased adventurers and found nothing. It was an accident, or something else. Not murder.

She disagreed. She felt it. Erin wandered over to the table where Regrika and Imenet were sitting. They’d both finished their plates. She tried to smile at them.

“Did you like your food?”

They both smiled at her. Regrika spoke softly, sympathy in her large brown eyes.

“I did. Thank you, Erin.”

Erin tried to smile again. It failed. She walked off. And the certainty in her heart grew.

Ryoka stood in the snow outside the inn. She hadn't run far. Just far enough away from the city and inn that no one could really see her. She waited. She knew what was coming.

There was no crunch of snow to alert her. No sound. Only Ivolethe's cold hand on Ryoka's cheek. She turned, and saw Ijvani standing behind her.

The skeleton's bones were black. Her golden eyes danced with flame. She held a staff in her hand that looked like it had been carved from a huge length of bone. Its tip was set with a golden gem. Ryoka swung at her.

“Ah.”

Ijvani caught the blow. She let go and Ryoka's leg struck an invisible barrier. Ryoka bent, grasping at her leg and made an incoherent sound.

“Fractured. Curious. You move quite adeptly for a Runner.”

A second voice issued from the skeleton's mouth. It was not Ijvani's hollow tones, but the quiet, deliberate words she had heard before. Az'kerash spoke as Ijvani lifted a finger and pointed, and Ryoka felt the sharp pain in her foot subside.

“You bastard. Go fuck yourself.”

She didn't thank him as she stood. Ryoka glared at Ijvani. The skeleton shifted in silent outrage. She heard Az'kerash sigh.

“Just as well that I did not bring Venitra. You are careless, Ryoka Griffin. My servants are devoted.”

“They're murderers!”

“I am well aware of their traits. As to the death of the Gnoll—that was Venitra’s error. She has suffered my ire for her actions.”

Ryoka waited. Ijvani stared at her.

“That’s it?”

Her voice was trembling. Ryoka strode towards the skeleton and met the invisible barrier in the snow. She strained against it, shouting at Az’kerash.

“That’s *it*? You kill someone and—that’s all you have to say?”

“Yes.”

There was no limit to the coldness in Az’kerash’s tone. Ijvani stared at Ryoka, her jaw moving as he replied softly.

“Do you expect me to apologize for his death? No. I am irate at my servant for revealing herself in this way and potentially compromising my disguise for her. That is all. I care not at all for the lives of your friends. I am here simply to warn you against foolish impulses.”

Ryoka ground her teeth together.

“You mean so that I don’t tell anyone else. Why shouldn’t I? If you’re going to kill my friends—”

The skeleton’s eyes flashed.

“I will kill them *all* if I am betrayed, girl. Do not mistake me. This is not a threat, but a promise.”

The fear that swept over Ryoka was sudden and chilling. She fell silent. Az’kerash went on.

“You have no power here. Know that Venitra will not take any more actions without my consent. If she does, she will prove herself to be a failure. That will stay her, you have my word.”

Did Ijvani shiver on hearing that? Ryoka stared at the skeleton, and then looked away.

“So I just have to wait while you decide my fate?”

“Yes.”

Contempt. No, not that. Indifference. That was all Az'kerash's voice held. Ryoka wanted to punch at Ijvani, and knew how futile it would be. She felt worthless. Helpless.

A flash of blue shot by her face. The flames in Ijvani's eyes brightened for a second—and then went out. The skeleton tumbled backwards, frost suddenly covering her entire body.

“What is happening? Ijvani?”

“I am under attack, master!”

Something blasted Ryoka off her feet. She tumbled down the slope of the hill she was standing on, and then felt another force lift her up. She struggled in the air and saw the black skeleton pointing at her. Lightning was crackling from her fingertips, across her entire body. Ryoka went limp.

“It was not Ryoka Griffin. Hold your spell.”

Az'kerash's voice snapped as Ijvani's head turned around, surveying the landscape. She paused as Ivolethe floated in front of her face. The faerie was raising one finger and glaring. Az'kerash's voice paused, and then grew thoughtful.

“What is that, Ijvani? I cannot see it, but I know something is there from your reactions.”

“A...Winter Sprite, my lord. It seems to be protective of Ryoka Griffin.”

“A Winter Sprite? Are you sure, Ijvani?”

“Yes, master. I see it in front of me.”

“How intriguing. I have never heard of a Winter Sprite befriending anyone before. Is it hostile, Ijvani?”

“I cannot tell, master. It is a blur to me.”

“I cannot see it. Put Ryoka Griffin down. Gently. Avoid antagonizing it, Ijvani. These Winter Sprites are considerably powerful in terms of magic, but they do not use force unless threatened. They are a form of elemental. Intelligent in some senses, but harmless.”

The look on Ivolethe's face made Ryoka want to laugh hysterically as she was lowered to the ground. The Frost Faerie hesitated, looking at

Ryoka, and then floated over to her shoulder. She sat there, glaring, as Ijvani turned back to Ryoka.

“That is all I wished to speak with you about. Ijvani, return to the inn.”

“*Yes, master.*”

The skeleton turned away. Ryoka clenched her fists, longing to shout, to say...something. But what could she say? There was no insult horrible enough, no word to describe him. She looked at Ijvani's back and thought she understood a bit of evil. It was in Az'kerash's voice. It was his sheer, awful contempt for everything he saw.

Ijvani walked through the snow, putting the illusion spells back on her body. Az'kerash spoke one last time through her mouth.

“Watch her, Ijvani. Don't let her out of your sight. And find out more about her. That is an order.”

She nodded.

“*Yes, master.*”

Ryoka sat in the snow, burying her face in her hands. She was lost. She didn't know what to do. And she couldn't ask for help from anyone. Because she understood now.

He was listening to everything she said. She was being watched. And there was no escaping. If Ryoka said anything, did anything, if she even *hinted*, she was sure Az'kerash would notice. Or his servant, Ijvani would.

She was stuck. Ryoka spoke to the air. It was the only thing she could speak to, the only thing that wouldn't draw attention to her.

“What should I do?”

She was just speaking to herself. That was what the spell saw. But Ryoka had one friend. One friend the Necromancer's magic couldn't see. And the Frost Faerie was no mere elemental. She hovered in front of Ryoka and her frozen eyes blazed.

“Fight.”

Ryoka stared at her. She felt a core of her resonate with Ivolethe’s words. There was no help for it, was there? She had to fight. If not...if not, her fate was in Az’kerash’s hands. And she could not trust him for anything like mercy.

“How could I defeat those two? I mean, it’s impossible. That bitch Venitra’s made of pure bone and she walked through an explosion unscathed when I first met her. As for Ijvani—how could I hope to kill them myself?”

Ryoka lay back in the snow, pretending to stare up at the sky. Ivolethe floated overhead, looking grave.

“By yourself? Ye could not do a thing. You know this. But you are not alone.”

“If I asked the others? That’s suicide. They couldn’t help if I managed to get word to them. Could they?”

She could imagine Zel putting up a fight, but Erin? What about the Gold-rank adventurers? Ivolethe considered this.

“If it came to a battle, perhaps they might win. Perhaps not. The lord of death watches his servants. He would cheat, as surely as you breathe, Ryoka Griffin. The leader of armies could fight well I think, but there are too many who would die.”

“It would be a bloodbath.”

Ivolethe nodded.

“Just so. But perhaps there is another way.”

Ryoka stared at her. She was desperate.

“What can I do? Tell me, please.”

She stared at the sky as the Frost Faerie flew next to her. Ivolethe whispered in Ryoka’s ear.

“There is one who fears neither death nor magic. He who rules above all others. A tyrant of flame.”

Teriarch. Ryoka inhaled the word before it could come out. Yes! Why hadn’t she thought of that? In the next moment she was deflated. Yes, there was someone she could ask. But he was—Ryoka shook her head in despair.

“It’s half a day’s run from Celum. And dangerous. I’d never make it—”

She’d be caught the instant she tried to run. Ivolethe nodded, understanding what Ryoka was saying without her saying it.

“Yes. Yes, they would hunt ye. But if you ran—if you had a distraction, then perhaps.”

“How? No. I could run for it. But there’s a cost, though, right?”

Ivolethe smiled sadly. Her form glistened. Another bit of her melted away and dropped, frozen and cold, into the snow next to Ryoka.

“There is always a cost. I bent the rules for you yesterday. I would bend them again. I can play...tricks on others. Tricks, Ryoka. It is not exactly interference. Bothering that fool with the spear was one trick. But I know many more. The servants of that lord of death may know their spells, but I have magic beyond what they know.”

“Maybe. Maybe I could just run away. But—what then? Would I have a chance? Or would I be killing myself either way?”

“Do you truly wish to know?”

The Frost Faerie’s gaze was ancient. Ryoka nodded. Ivolethe closed her eyes, and then nodded. She flew up and Ryoka sat up in the snow. She watched as Ivolethe looked.

She looked backwards, then forwards, and then through Ryoka. Ivolethe’s gaze traced objects that were not there. Her eyes were distant, aloof, immortal.

Ryoka averted her gaze. Of all the things she had seen her friend do, this unnerved her the most. In that moment, she felt the difference between the two. Because Ivolethe was immortal, for all she behaved like a creature of this earth. And the undying look at the world as it truly is, as it will be, and as it was.

Dust.

At last, Ivolethe shook her head. She alighted on Ryoka’s palm and looked up at her. There was infinite compassion in her gaze, infinite sorrow.

“You would save those who can be saved.”

Ryoka inhaled. Ivolethe held up a hand.

“Aye, but the cost. The cost is great, Ryoka. For when I look down that road, I see death, Ryoka Griffin. I see your death. It is unavoidable.”

There was a churning pit in Ryoka’s stomach, a clump of fear. It had been there since she’d looked back in the alleyway and seen Venitra’s face. Now the fear subsided. Ryoka felt calm. She stood up, holding Ivolethe, and looked north.

She could save them all. She could do it. Ryoka took a step towards the inn, towards the door that led to Celum. She took another step, and then realized something was wrong.

She wasn't moving. Ryoka looked down. Her feet were planted in the snow. She tried to raise her left foot. It didn't twitch. Ryoka stared. She couldn't make her legs move.

She was too afraid.

Erin stood in her kitchen, in front of a freshly washed cutting board. Her inn was empty. There was only Lyonette, Mrsha, and one or two others in the inn. Everyone else had left.

Mrsha was crying. She would cry, and then howl. It was a painful noise. Her throat was already raw, but nothing could make the Gnoll child stop. Lyonette was crying too. Erin could hear her sobbing. Their room was right over the kitchen upstairs.

Erin wasn't crying. She stared at the cutting board. Then she looked along the kitchen counter. It was covered in food. Or rather, ingredients.

Choice cuts of meat, ham on the bone, wizened vegetables, the last of the winter's harvests, flour, salt, and rarer ingredients still. Ground up Corusdeer horn, the skin of some kind of salamander or newt, a goopy mess that was something's eyeball—ingredients from Octavia. They were all neatly arranged, but Erin hadn't begun cooking. She stared at the ingredients, and then turned as someone coughed and knocked quietly on the doorjamb of the kitchen.

"What do you want, Pisces? I'm not serving food."

"Perish the thought."

The [Necromancer] delicately stepped into the kitchen, surveying the counter full of food. He paused and looked at Erin before clearing his throat.

"I ah, only wished to extend my apologies, Erin."

“You?”

“Yes. I realize it may be...tactless coming from me, but I feel that offering my sympathies is only appropriate—”

Pisces caught Erin’s eye and broke off. He paused for a moment, sniffed, wrinkled his nose, and then spoke. Differently, this time.

“I am sorry. That’s all I wanted to say. I know I am not the person you would wish to turn to, but Ceria is about to leave for the city. Liscor, that is. I believe she and the others intend to drink and leave you in peace. However, I could ask her to stay, or find Miss Selys—”

“No. No, Pisces, that’s kind of you, but no.”

Erin shook her head. She relaxed a bit, and turned to Pisces. He looked uncharacteristically somber. But his words sounded as genuine as they had ever been. She was glad to hear it. Pisces stared at her kitchen.

“Are you cooking something?”

“Yeah. I’m thinking about it.”

He nodded.

“That may be a good way to, ah, relieve stress.”

“It’s not for that.”

“Oh? If it is tomorrow’s meal or tonight’s you are worried about, I am sure that closing your inn would not be—”

“It’s not that, Pisces. Thanks for asking. It’s...it’s actually about Regrika and Imenet.”

Pisces’ gaze sharpened slightly.

“What do you mean by that?”

Erin heard a choked noise from above. She looked up and saw Pisces closing his eyes for a second. Erin ignored Lyonette’s voice as she spoke.

“She didn’t like my cooking.”

“Who?”

“Regrika. And that Imenet guy. They say they like it, but they hated it. I can tell.”

Erin gestured to one of the plates lying on the counter. Pisces stared at the grilled cheese sandwich.

“Those are not typically Gnoll foods, I admit—”

“No. They didn’t like last night’s meals either. They ate a lot, but they didn’t like a thing. Not the steak, not the casserole—nothing. Not even the drinks.”

The [Necromancer] frowned and stroked at his chin as he eyed Erin.

“That is a curious certainty, Erin. How do you know?”

She looked at him. Pisces flinched and avoided meeting her eyes. Erin looked back at her empty kitchen counter.

“I’m an [Innkeeper].”

There was something burning in her mind, something hot behind her eyes. She hadn’t meant to turn it on Pisces. After a second he cleared his throat.

“So this attempt at cooking is...?”

“I wonder what they *do* like eating. That’s all.”

Erin stared at the counter. There was a feeling she had, like when she was about to solve a chess problem, or she felt like she had come up with a great move in a game of chess. It was as if she stood on the edge of certainty. She had that feeling now. There were pieces. Just pieces, but...

She looked at Pisces.

“Pisces. Is it possible to deceive a truth detection spell? Is it possible to lie when someone’s using one of those stones on you?”

He froze. Pisces stared at Erin, and she felt him searching her face. He hesitated, gnawed on one lip, raised a finger, and then lowered it. Then he nodded and leaned forwards to speak softly.

“Practically? No. I could not do it. Nor could Ceria, Typhenous...a Named Adventurer would probably lack the ability to do so. But in theory? Yes. The current Archmages of Wistram could most likely affect such a spell. And such stones are not...flawless. There are ways to deceive simpler

versions of the spell, which is why more expensive and accurate versions of truth-telling artifacts exist.”

“Thanks. That helps.”

Pisces nodded, but didn’t pull back. He lowered his voice further.

“I do not wish to tell you what to do. However. Perhaps, Erin, it might be better to...grieve. And let whatever you are thinking of go.”

He was not prepared for the hand that grabbed the front of his robes. Pisces yelped and then stared at Erin. His face was inches away from hers. Erin stared at him.

“If you know anything, Pisces, tell me.”

He jerked back, brushing down his clean robes. He shook his head. Erin glared, but he kept shaking his head. When he looked her in the eye, it was with open honesty.

“It is just a feeling. Less than that. I cannot sense anything about them. Anything at all. Rather, it is my instincts that prompt me, not magic. Just my intuition.”

“What does it tell you?”

Pisces hesitated. He turned his head and stared back at the common room. It was empty of course. But he still lowered his voice.

“They frighten me, Erin. They frighten me terribly. And I do not understand why.”

There was no confusing which ‘they’ he meant. Erin nodded.

“They bother me too.”

Pisces stared at her. He opened his mouth as if to say something, and then turned away. He walked towards the kitchen’s exit and then turned back.

“Be careful.”

Then he was gone. Erin stood in the kitchen, and heard a howl from upstairs. She closed her eyes. And thought.

Erin didn’t know much. She wasn’t smart. She couldn’t figure out why Brunkr had died, or what the motives were, or figure anything else out

about where he'd been found or his injuries.

His injuries. Erin's hand tightened on her counter. She relaxed. Slowly.

No, she couldn't figure any of that out. But she had one certainty, and one alone. Brunkr had been murdered. He'd told her that he wouldn't enter the dungeon. He'd promised her he wouldn't risk his life, not carelessly. He'd promised her that.

And she knew Brunkr. She knew people. So she knew he had been murdered. As for who had done it—Erin knew people. It was just a hunch.

She stared at the counter. She had no proof. None at all. She heard Mrsha howl again and Lyonette try to stop her. But the girl broke down and began to sob rhythmically. It went on and on. Erin stared at the ingredients.

Food for Regrika Blackpaw. Which one was it? What would she use? If she were making food for that one person. For Regrika. For her. What would she make?

Erin's hand moved unconsciously. She stared at what she grabbed, and then put it on the board in front of her. The world was slowing. Everything was crystalizing around Erin, becoming a single moment. A terrible moment. Lyonette was crying, Mrsha was howling and then pausing for breath, and then howling again.

Time slowed. The intervals between Lyonette's sobs and Mrsha's howling grew longer. Erin's hands moved. She grabbed a hammer. She grabbed a knife. She pushed ingredients around, poured, assembled. Baked. It was all one moment, one slowly unwinding scene of horror.

And then it was over. All the pieces fell into place. Erin looked down at what Regrika Blackpaw would eat. She stared at the dish she'd created. And she knew.

The world was ringing. Or humming. It felt like everything was vibrating. Ryoka's heart was beating too fast to keep still. She walked up towards Erin's inn, holding something in her hands.

A bit of parchment. An inkpot. And a quill. She'd bought them from the market. She cautiously pushed open the door to the inn.

"Hello? Erin? Anyone?"

There was no one inside. Not Lyonette, or Mrsha. Erin was gone too. Ryoka took a shuddering breath. That was...fine.

It was dark as she ascended the stairs. A bit of blue lit the way. Ivolethe flew slowly next to Ryoka as the girl walked into the room she shared with Lyonette and Mrsha. Ryoka slowly sat on the floor. She put the bit of parchment on the floor and pulled out the quill and inkpot. She opened the inkpot and picked up the quill.

Then she stared at the parchment lying on the ground. Ryoka's heart beat wildly. She hesitated. She didn't know what to write.

But she knew she had to write it.

She stared at the blank piece of parchment for a long time. Then she dipped her quill in the ink and wrote. Just a few lines. There were no good words she could think of, but Ryoka had no time to come up with some. She was running out of time. So she wrote and it was done.

Next, Ryoka folded the parchment and tucked it into her belt pouch. Then she took her belt pouches off and put it in her room. She took the bag of holding off her belt and put it next to the pouches. She shifted her Runner's pack to hide both items and stood up.

"That's it. That's all she wrote. I can go now."

Slowly, she walked out of the room and down the stairs. Ryoka felt like she was in a trance. Everything seemed vast around her, and she felt as though she were looking down at herself. The door to Celum was right in front of her.

Ryoka stopped in front of it. She looked to one side. Ivolethe hovered there, a piece of infinity. Melting away. The Frost Faerie was smiling. Gently. It was the first time Ryoka had seen her look this way. She almost seemed...proud.

"I guess this is it, Ivolethe."

“Yes.”

The faerie nodded once. Ryoka gulped.

“Do you think I’m a coward for being afraid?”

The tiny immortal shook her head.

“No. I would never scorn you for that.”

“Thank you. And tell them—tell Erin and Mrsha and Lyonette—tell them—”

Words failed her. Ryoka turned away. Ivolethe nodded.

“I will see your end.”

“Thank you.”

Ryoka opened the door. She took a breath. Then she stepped through.

And began to run.

Dusk had ended. Night was upon the world when Az’kerash contacted his two servants.

Report.

Venitra stood in her disguise as Regrika Blackpaw, Ijvani as Imenet, just outside the city limits. They stood next to the wall and spoke to the air.

“I have discovered that Ryoka Griffin is a known City Runner who has completed deliveries to the High Passes, and to Lady Magnolia Reinhart. Of note, she has recently travelled to Invrisil via magical carriage. It was sent by the Reinhart family.”

Indeed? That is intriguing. Reinhart knows of me, I am sure. But why would she concern herself with a City Runner? Venitra. What have you discovered?

Venitra’s words were quick and eager. She rushed to speak, afraid to disappoint her master any further.

“She is the caretaker for the Gnoll child, and she has links to the adventurers in the inn, master. Not the Gold-rank ones. The group with the half-Elf, the [Necromancer], the Antinium and the woman with damaged arms—they are known as the Horns of Hammerad.”

Ah, yes. I recall. The young [Necromancer]. What of the [Innkeeper]? Erin Solstice?

The two undead shifted and looked at each other. Venitra was the first to speak.

“She has a magical chessboard, master. And she is known as the best player of the game. She appeared months ago out of nowhere and began running the inn. The old one was destroyed. She obtained the magical door thanks to her connections with the Horns of Hammerad as well. She...she is rumored to be the one who defeated a powerful Flesh Worm known as Skinner. The Antinium are said to consider her a friend, and she can create magical dishes which act as temporary enchantments for those who consume them. It is said that she had a skeleton as a servant before, and she is capable of making wondrous music. She can apparently shoot blood from her crotch and—”

What was that?

“She can shoot blood from—it is what we heard, master.”

There was a long silence as both Venitra and Ijvani waited. Az’kerash’s mental voice sounded peculiar when he replied.

Do you mean...no. I see rumor has mixed with fact, Venitra. Try to differentiate the two. How peculiar, though. Erin Solstice and Ryoka Griffin. Both are odd in their own way. Very odd. Where is Ryoka Griffin now, Ijvani?

The skeleton mage immediately responded.

“In Celum, master. The other city. She is sitting in a tavern, drinking.”

Good. I have made my decision. Venitra, your careless actions have endangered the disguise that you have built up over the years. Your reputation as a Named Adventurer is at risk and I do not trust you to remain in Liscor without incident any longer.

Venitra hung her head. Ijvani gave her a grin only a skeleton could give in triumph. Both snapped to attention as Az’kerash continued.

However, Ryoka Griffin is an unstable variable I dislike having. She is not trustworthy I feel, even if restrained by spells. Thus, my order to you is simple. Bring me back her head.

The two undead looked up. Venitra slowly smiled.

“Just her head, master?”

That is all I require. It must be undamaged, Venitra. Completely. The rest of her body may be disposed of, but I require the head frozen or kept in stasis. Take action tonight, and make sure you are not observed. Do *not* kill anyone or reveal yourselves to anyone besides Ryoka. Make sure her remains are disposed of outside the city—I will teleport Oom to you and have him reveal himself as the murderer of both Ryoka and the Gnoll. Is all that understood?

“Yes master!”

“Yes master.”

Go, then. If there are any complications, contact me at once.

The connection broke. The two undead looked at each other. Venitra was smiling broadly. Ijvani nodded her head.

“The magical door is in the inn. Let us go to Celum. I will draw Ryoka Griffin out with a spell. Then you will have your chance, Venitra.”

“Good.”

“Leave part of her for me.”

“I will not promise that.”

Ijvani shook her head in annoyance. Venitra strode off through the snow, eagerly heading away from the city. The skeleton followed. They walked towards the Wandering Inn. Both of the undead were smiling.

The door to Erin’s inn swung open and Regrika stepped through. She was surprised to be greeted by a shout.

“Hey, come in! Regrika? It’s great that you’re here!”

The Named Adventurer blinked as Erin bustled over. The [Innkeeper] had a mug in one hand and she smiled at Regrika and Imenet.

“Greetings, Erin. You were looking for me?”

“Oh yeah! I wanted to show you something. I had Ishkr go into the city to look for you—guess he must have missed you!”

“No doubt.”

Regrika glanced around the inn. It was quiet and empty. There were too many memories of Brunkr here for most people to want to return, but there were some customers.

Halrac glanced up as Imenet closed the door behind the two adventurers. He grunted. Regrika looked at him and the rest of his team, Griffon Hunt. They were sitting in a corner of the room, clearly deep into their cups. The tables around them were deserted. Some were overturned.

It looked as though there had been a fight.

“Sorry. People are a bit touchy right now.”

Erin lowered her voice as she ushered the two adventurers to a table. Regrika coughed.

“I am sorry Erin, but I am afraid we did not come here for a meal. We have business in Celum, actually.”

She indicated Erin’s magical door. Erin made a disappointed face.

“Come on, sit. Please? I made a new dish, all for you!”

Regrika and Imenet exchanged a glance. The Drake coughed.

“As delightful as that sounds, Miss Solstice, we are rather busy. We’d like to enter Celum, unless you charge a transportation fee...?”

He got no further because someone called out behind him. The two adventurers turned and saw Jelaqua Ivirith, holding a mug and laughing over her plates with Seborn and Moore.

“Celum, huh? Sounds like fun! Those Humans know how to party. But have a drink with us, first!”

The Selphid drained her cup and grinned at the Named Adventurers. Regrika hesitated. Erin pulled out the chair.

“Just a taste? I promise you, you’ll love what I came up with! Here—sit over right over here so you don’t have to deal with the two grumpy Drakes.”

“I heard that, you bumbling Human.”

Wall Lord Ilvriss sat up at his table. He glared at Erin. Zel sighed and put one claw on his shoulder. Regrika sat, clearly reluctant, and Imenet joined him. Two mugs appeared on their table and Erin rushed into the kitchen. She came back out with two plates of what looked to the Gnoll like steak.

“Hmm. That is a steak, yes? I believe I had one two days ago, Miss Solstice.”

Erin beamed at her.

“Yes! But it’s not just any steak. This one’s seasoned specially. Try it, come on! Please?”

The Gnoll and Drake looked at each other. Imenet coughed as he prodded his steak with a fork and knife. It looked rather hard. Regrika sighed.

“Miss Erin, I appreciate the hospitality. I truly do. But please, you need not force yourself. We understand the recent death of Brunkr has affected you all. It has hurt us too. He seemed like a fine [Warrior]. That is to say—[Knight]. My apologies. I would not like to intrude.”

Silence fell over the inn as the adventurers drank. Zel closed his eyes and Ilvriss scowled into his mug. Erin looked down at the ground.

“Yeah. That was—sorry.”

She wiped at her eyes. Regrika smiled sympathetically and reached a paw out to touch Erin’s hand. The [Innkeeper] moved back a bit and shook her head briskly.

“I don’t want to be down. And I don’t want to be pushy, but I just thought I’d be hospitable, you know? That’s what I do. I’m an [Innkeeper]. So this steak—”

She edged it close to Regrika. The Gnoll hesitated. Erin looked at her pleadingly.

“Just let me know how it tastes. I worked really hard on it.”

There was no way around it. Regrika sighed and cut into the steak. It took a bit of work to slice a section away, and it *crunched* as she popped it into her mouth. The Gnoll chewed obligingly. And then her eyes widened. Across the table, Imenet was making the same expression.

“Good?”

Erin looked intently at their faces. Regrika’s response was to cut off another bit of steak and chew it. She gulped and looked at Erin, deeply surprised.

“It’s...*excellent*. Very tasty. How did you...?”

Beneath the table, Imenet kicked her. Regrika coughed.

“You’ve outdone yourself again, Miss Solstice. I am quite happy with this dish. Did you...spice it differently, somehow?”

“Something like that. Go ahead! I’m glad you enjoy it!”

The young woman beamed as both adventures began to scarf down the steaks. When they were done, there were only crumbs. Regrika leaned back and eyed her plate. Then she looked at Imenet. The Drake was raising both his eyebrows at Regrika.

“A truly fine meal. The best I’ve had in...forever, I believe. Erin, I would love to know how you made it.”

“Really?”

Erin looked over the moon. Regrika nodded.

“I would pay much for the recipe. And I will certainly come back tonight.”

Imenet curled his tail up in delight.

“Yes. Tonight for as long as we are staying. What *is* it made of? I haven’t tasted...taste...”

Both adventurers leaned over the table towards Erin. She hesitated.

“Well, it’s a bit of a secret. But I guess I could tell you.”

“Yes, please do.”

“You really want to hear?”

“I would pay much for it, yes.”

“Okay, then. Listen close.”

Both adventurers leaned in. Erin whispered.

“It’s *bone*.”

Regrika blinked.

“By bone, do you mean meat off the bone—”

“No, I mean, it’s bone. You ate bones of dead animals. There was no meat in that. Not one bit.”

Both Gnoll and Drake looked at Erin. She took a step back and pointed at their plates. Her smile was still on her face, but it had changed.

“You want to know what that was? It was bones, dried and ground up into dust. And other bones soaked in pig’s blood from Octavia’s shop and mixed with mana potions. I baked it together using marrow as glue. Then I dyed it with more blood. It looks only a little bit like a steak. No one else would ever eat it. No one except you two.”

Regrika stared at Erin. The hairs on her body began to rise. Erin continued. She had a very big smile on her face.

“And I put poison in it. Bad poison. The kind that can kill Shield Spiders. I got it from Octavia. I put in a lot. Funny. It didn’t seem to matter if I did. I knew you’d like it.”

“I don’t understand. Is this some kind of joke...?”

Imenet tried to laugh. Erin turned to him. Her smile had become wide. Her eyes were bright.

“No. I didn’t expect you to actually eat my food. But you did. You ate it and didn’t notice a thing. You thought it was steak because it was red and shaped like it. That’s not normal.”

“Well, I—”

“And another thing. You didn’t like any of my other dishes. I could tell. You didn’t like drinking beer, and you didn’t like the cake. Not one bit. And you lied about that. I guess that’s normal. Everyone’s got different tastes

and all, but then I got to thinking. Hey Regrika, you're a really weird Gnoll, you know that?"

"Really? I think I'm quite normal, yes?"

Regrika bared her teeth. Erin did the same.

"No. I mean, you smell like a Gnoll and you act like one. And all the Gnolls love you, but guess what I noticed? It was a little thing. You never really mentioned Mrsha. Not once."

Imenet glanced swiftly at his companion. Regrika hesitated and then appeared indifferent.

"Mrsha? Oh. The little Gnoll cub. She was very cute. What about her?"

"You think she's normal, don't you?"

The Named Adventurer paused.

"No. But I did not mention her because it would have been rude. A Gnoll cub being raised by a Human is strange. However—"

"You don't know what I'm talking about, do you?"

Erin stared at Regrika. Imenet's eyes widened. He hissed at Regrika.

"The white fur!"

"That's right."

Erin stepped back from the table. Her eyes were on Regrika. The Gnoll stared back, no longer smiling.

"White fur. That's bad...luck? I don't know. But I know that every Gnoll knows what it means, even if they won't tell me. Every Gnoll. Ishkr was born in Liscor and he still knows about white fur. But you, you didn't bat an eyelash. You asked whose kid Mrsha was."

Silence. Regrika shifted in her seat. She looked around and suddenly saw a different room. The Gold-rank adventurers from Griffon Hunt were standing up at their table, adjusting their belts, nodding at each other and spreading out. On the opposite side of the room, the Halfseekers were already in position. Jelaqua lifted her two-handed flail, not trying to hide it.

"You don't like normal food. You lied about killing Brunkr. And you don't know about white Gnolls like Mrsha, which *every Gnoll knows*

about.”

Erin’s voice was hard and loud. She was walking backwards, back behind a table where two Drakes were getting to their feet. Zel and Ilvriss walked forwards. A sword was in the Wall Lord’s hands. Zel’s claws were open.

“I see. We were discovered.”

Regrika’s voice was very calm. She remained sitting at the table as the Gold-rank adventurers spread around the room and the two Drakes stopped in front of their table. She smiled at Zel Shivertail, and then looked at Erin.

“One question. How did you know I lied about Brunkr? I passed the truth detection spell the Antinium gave me.”

Erin looked at her and shook her head.

“Isn’t it obvious? It wasn’t about the truth crystal. Everyone was looking at that, but I could tell without it. You gave it all away here.”

She tapped her mouth. Regrika blinked.

“What?”

“It was your smile. You smiled like Mrsha does when she’s been naughty. Kids are bad liars. And so are you.”

Erin looked at Regrika. She reached for something lying on a table and came up with a knife and a frying pan. Halrac growled at her.

“Don’t be a fool! Get out of here!”

Erin didn’t move.

“I want to know who killed Brunkr.”

Ilvriss spat. His eyes were on Regrika and his grip was steady on his sword.

“I don’t care about the Gnoll. But justice is justice and I won’t have the law broken by a Named Adventurer. You, Gnoll! Tell me. Why have you been asking about Ryoka Griffin all day? What’s your connection with her?”

Zel shifted. He stared at Regrika and then Ilvriss. He was wary, his stance low.

“Who are you? What are you doing here?”

Silence. The two adventurers looked at each other. Regrika stared at Imenet. Imenet nodded. Losing her temper, Revi shouted as she raised a glowing talisman.

“Well? *Answer us!*”

Regrika exploded backwards in her chair. She rolled out of it and onto her feet as the table shot towards Moore and Seborn. The half-Giant was knocked off his feet by the impact and Seborn dove out of the way.

“*Damn it! Attack!*”

Ilvriss and Zel charged forwards at once, towards Regrika. Ulrien and Jelaqua leapt forwards at the same moment as the other adventurers leapt backwards. Halrac looked around and shouted.

“*Watch out! The Drake—*”

Zel turned. Imenet had vanished in the moment when Regrika moved. Now he reappeared in front of Zel and Ilvriss. Halrac loosed a shot. Zel swiped.

The arrow struck Imenet in the back of the neck. The claws tore open his face. But the Drake still moved. He placed a hand on Zel’s stomach and one of Ilvriss’ arms and spoke.

“[Lesser Teleport].”

They vanished in a *pop* of air. Jelaqua swore and she and Ulrien rushed at Regrika. The Gnoll had her massive sword and shield in one hand. She raised it and blocked Jelaqua’s first swing. Ulrien slashed at her from behind with his greatsword. The blow skated off her armored back as Regrika twisted to one side.

“Typhenous, cover us! Revi! Summons! Erin, get clear! Jelaqua—”

Regrika turned. Ulrien swore and attacked.

“[Devastating Slash]!”

His sword changed trajectory mid-cut. It swerved as Regrika lifted her shield to block and shot down, to her unguarded legs. Ulrien swung with all his might, and his blade bit into the Gnoll’s furred leg. And stopped.

The greatsword shuddered to a halt, buried two inches deep into the Gnoll's leg. Ulrien stared at his blade as the force of his cut travelled back up into his hands. He tried to step back and wrench his sword free from the impact.

“*Weak.*”

A sword rose. Regrika brought it down. Ulrien raised his bare arm to protect himself. The sword connected with his arm and there was a *flash* of light. Something—an amulet exploded on Ulrien's chest. He stumbled back, his arm still intact.

The second sword stroke took off his head. Ulrien's body stood for a moment, and then the big man's corpse collapsed forwards. Jelaqua howled as she lashed Regrika from all sides. The Gnoll stood under the barrage, and then turned and struck. Jelaqua choked as the sword stabbed through her stomach and then leapt back.

“Ulrien?”

Halrac stared, the bow and arrow he'd drawn frozen in his hands. Typhenous roared and threw bolts of magic that blasted into the Gnoll—

And did nothing. She stood in the center of the room, raising her arms, laughing. Regrika turned to Erin as the [Innkeeper] stood frozen in the middle of her inn. The Gnoll's blade ran with blood. She pointed around the room, at the other adventurers. She ended with Erin.

“You are all dead.”

4.30

Blood dripped from Regrika Blackpaw's sword and onto the ground. Erin couldn't take her eyes off it.

Ulrien was dead. The brave Gold-rank adventurer and leader of Griffon Hunt lay on the ground, headless. His greatsword was still embedded in Regrika's leg. The Gnoll didn't seem concerned by it. She flicked her sword down and knocked the blade loose. As she did, the adventurers attacked.

Halrac howled as he put two arrows to his bow and shot them.

"[Double Shot]!"

The Gnoll turned and raised her shield. An explosion of fire and some kind of acid burst over her shield. Some sprayed across her face. She didn't flinch. She turned and then caught another blow from Jelaqua on her other side. She was too quick, too strong!

Erin stared at Ulrien as Regrika fought, stepping around his body. He was dead. Just like that. His magical amulet had protected him from one blow, but not two. It felt impossible. He was a Gold-rank adventurer, and he was Ulrien! She had never really talked to him one-on-one, but he was like a rock. Solid. Dependable. He held his team together and never seemed to get worried.

He couldn't die so easily. That was what she felt. Someone screamed. Revi hurled five talismans and glowing figures rose from the floor. Regrika cut one down and then another before the summoned beings could fully appear. She turned and ran her sword deep into Moore's abdomen. The half-Giant grunted, and then *punched* her. The impact made the floor shake.

His fist broke.

Erin stood behind the table where Zel and Ilvriss had disappeared with the Drake [Mage], Imenet. She stared at Ulrien. He'd been the first to agree to help her when she'd told him and the others what she suspected. Without hesitation. She'd accused a Named Adventurer and he'd asked her to explain herself while the others were exclaiming or asking if she was crazy. And when she asked for help, set the trap up—he'd agreed at once.

He'd said yes, although Revi was throwing a fit and Typhenous said that it would ruin their reputation if Erin were wrong. But Ulrien had looked her in the eye for a few moments and then nodded. That was all. He'd trusted her.

He'd said yes. And now he was dead. Erin looked at him, and then remembered Brunkr. Then she looked up and saw Regrika was laughing. The Gnoll spun, catching a cascade of magical bullets shooting from Typhenous' fingertips on her shield and then kicked a chair at Halrac.

The [Scout] dodged out of the way as the wood smashed into one of the tables he was taking cover behind. The impact knocked the table back, sending it skidding to the far wall. Erin stared in disbelief. All that from a kicked chair? She was too strong!

"Get away, you idiot!"

Someone seized her shoulder. Revi pulled Erin back as she raised a glowing talisman. She hurled it to the ground and a third figure rose. Three of the glowing warriors, all String People, took positions between her and Regrika. Two were warriors, one had a staff. They charged the Gnoll as the spectral mage swung his staff and shot shards of ice and earth at the Gnoll.

The spells lashed the Gnoll's form without effect. She cut down one warrior with a slash as he approached. Her blade cut right through the shield he'd raised and into his head. He vanished in a shower of yellow motes of light. The second stabbed into Regrika's armored side; his blade skated across the metal without effect.

A spiked flail's head caught Regrika across the back of the head as she swung her shield and scythed through the second summoned warrior. Regrika didn't stumble, but slashed backwards. Jelaqua sprang back, cursing.

"The hell is that? My flail's not doing a thing!"

Regrika slashed at Jelaqua and the Selphid backed up, shielded by a rain of spells coming from Typhenous, Revi, and Moore. Bolts of energy splashed across Regrika's body, a cluster of vines ensnared her legs—she raised her shield and caught a glowing purple orb from Typhenous. Again, the spell was blocked as the orb *exploded*, sending fragments of light

shooting across the room. Where the fragments landed the floor, walls, and furniture burst into flame.

“My spells aren’t working!”

Revi screamed at the others. Typhenous pointed at Regrika with his staff as she advanced on Jelaqua, but her shield was up, blocking his direction. Moore’s vines were entangling her as the half-Giant chanted and pointed his staff, clutching his belly with his other hand, but they barely slowed her.

A flash of movement. Regrika half-turned. Too late. Seborn buried two knives in her shield arm, slashing her exposed black fur. He dodged away as she swung at him, his form blurring into a shadow. His voice was astonished.

“My knives did nothing! Her fur—”

His blades glowed with magic, but they’d left no imprint on Regrika’s arm. She grinned at him, and then turned to block another spell from Typhenous. Jelaqua strode forwards, gritting her teeth and shouting at Seborn.

“I’m Rampaging! Get back!”

The Selphid threw herself forward, her arms and body turning into a blur. She moved too quickly for Erin to follow and lashed with her two-handed flail in every direction, striking, dodging, and striking again.

Erin watched, numb, and saw it was another bad matchup. If Ulrien had died because Regrika was too strong and too well protected somehow, Jelaqua was a victim of the same problem. She rained blows on the Gnoll from every direction. She was like lightning, unpredictable and impossible to block or evade, much less dodge. But Regrika stood in the whirlwind of steel and didn’t fall back. The flail struck her repeatedly *and she did not move*. The flail did nothing to her. Her body was too strong.

Why?

Her sword rose. This time Halrac shot three arrows in rapid succession into her back. Crackling lightning earthed itself on Regrika’s armor; to no effect. Typhenous’ spell was blocked. Moore’s spray of thorns showered Regrika’s left side and Seborn cut at the same leg Ulrien had struck. A frying pan hit Regrika in the back of the head.

Nothing stopped her. Jelaqua's blurring arms paused and she raised her flail to block. The sword knocked the flail out of her grip. The Selphid swore and the sword took the top of her head off as she ducked. She fell.

Regrika kicked Jelaqua's body across the room, catching Seborn and tossing him into a wall. She grinned, and locked eyes with Erin. The knife spun towards her eye and Regrika twisted her head. The blade missed.

She charged across the room, her footsteps like thunder on the floor. The other adventurers shouted, and Erin tried to run. Too slow. Revi raised a glowing fragment of horn and the bloody sword cut her from shoulder to hip. She fell, bloodless. Regrika stood over Erin and grinned. Then she paused. She looked up to the ceiling and spoke one word.

"Master?"

She'd killed two Gold-rank adventurers already. The feeling of killing the third, of slicing the [Summoner] in half, gave Venitra a rush of pleasure. She raised her shield and caught a third spell from the old mage as he screamed curses at her.

He was the only threat. His spells could damage her if not blocked. However, her shield was enchanted and capable of resisting any magic he might use. So long as she kept him in view and didn't let the others escape, they were helpless. Her analysis of the situation was flawless, she knew.

In battle, Venitra's mind was cool and calculating. She was not affected by the chaos of combat and she could think with perfect clarity as spells and arrows flew around her. It was her luxury to indulge in emotion, but she was not bound by it.

Three dead, and now the innkeeper. Venitra would take extreme pleasure in this. She raised her sword, heedless of the voices of the other adventurers and the arrow that broke on the back of her head. Her body was made of spelled bone; the [Scout] could not injure her with his enchanted arrows, not while he thought she was made of flesh or warded by magic.

Her entire body was armor. In many ways her shield was useless. She was a shield.

Venitra.

A voice, a presence connected to her mind. A revelation from above. Venitra paused. In the heat of battle she looked up.

“Master?”

He spoke to her in a flash of images, a torrent of thought. Thought was far faster than any spell, or the quickest arrow. Her master reached into Venitra’s mind and appraised all that had occurred in the moments between Ijvani removing Zel Shivertail and the other Drake.

I see. I will attend to Ijvani. She is outmatched by far but will keep Shivertail and the Lord of the Wall occupied. You will go after Ryoka.

“Yes, my lord.”

If they were spoken as words, it was only because Venitra felt more comfortable this way. Time had slowed to a crawl in this instantaneous communication between the two. The second arrow the [Scout] had loosed was still in the air, crawling towards Venitra’s right shoulder. They thought and spoke together in the moments between.

Dispose of the Gold-rank adventurers if you are able, but do not waste time on them. Learn from this battle. They are inferior to you, but still a threat. Go after Ryoka Griffin with all haste. Bring me back her head, undamaged. She is in Celum. Trace the spell Ijvani laid on her.

“It will be done, master.”

I will assist you if necessary, but I must focus on Ijvani as well. Lastly, Venitra. You will not kill Erin Solstice. Nor will you allow her to be harmed. That is an order.

“But master!”

Erin Solstice was frozen in front of her, eyes wide, hand raised to ward off a sword blow that would end her. Venitra longed to strike, but she felt her master’s will pressing down on her. She felt his displeasure and reluctantly obeyed. His mental sending faded away in her mind with a final rebuke.

Enough. Go.

The arrow caught Venitra’s shoulder and exploded into shrapnel. Venitra snarled in her guise as Regrika Blackpaw and spun. She walked away from Erin and towards the [Scout] who already had another arrow drawn. The girl would live. For now.

Zel Shivertail fell out of the sky, cursing and still slashing at the Drake [Mage] in front of him. He caught only air. Then he hit the ground.

“*Argh!*”

The impact knocked the wind out of him and cracked the paving stones he’d landed on. Zel lay there for a second and then rolled upright. He looked around and then up. He should have been dead. If not for his Skills, he probably would have been; he’d fallen from rooftop level onto the ground wearing armor.

But because he did have Skills, he was alive. Zel glanced around and realized he was in Liscor. The dark streets were empty. But where—

“[Grand Fireball].”

He heard the voice from above. Zel turned and saw the blazing glow. He turned and ran.

The explosion kicked him across the street. The heat burnt his scales. Zel shouted in pain and fury as he caught flame. But he lived through it. And he turned to see the Drake with purple scales, staff in hand, standing on the roof of a burning building.

Watching him.

Imenet raised his staff and Zel sprinted down an alleyway. He felt the ground erupt behind him and heard screaming. From inside the buildings. Dead gods, there were innocent people sleeping inside! But the crazed [Mage] didn't seem to care. More spells ripped up the street and Zel ran through the alley into another street.

One of the rules for fighting a mage was never to let them see you. And to get close. He hunkered down and heard a sound in the distance. It sounded like...cursing?

He looked up. On the roof of another building he spotted a Drake in expensive armor, looking around as he clung to the tiles with one claw. A bared sword was in the other.

"Ilvriss!"

At the sound of his name, the other Drake looked over and spotted Zel. He dropped to the ground. It was a long fall, but the Drake landed as lightly as a cat. Some kind of protective spell, no doubt. He ran over to the [General], crouched, sword at the ready.

"What the hell happened, Shivertail? That mage teleported us—"

"He's blasting the street looking for me!"

Zel spoke grimly as he heard more *thumps* and now more screams. People were waking up. He started as he saw the earth rise at the far end of the street. The paved road ripped upwards and formed a jagged wall of stone.

"He's trying to box us in."

Ilvriss hissed, his tail lashing with fury. He twisted at one of the rings on his fingers. It flashed, summoning his bodyguards, no doubt. Zel nodded.

“Or slow us down. Regrika Blackpaw’s back at the inn!”

“I know that! Let the Gold-rank adventurers fight her. I want that traitor *dead*.”

Zel didn’t argue with that. He looked around the alley, and then raced back down it with Ilvriss behind him. They ran into the next street and Ilvriss cursed.

One of the buildings, an apartment, was fully aflame. Zel could hear people screaming inside, but he had no time to go to them. Imenet was standing in the center of the street. He had erected walls of stone around him and was standing in front of some glowing runes. Ilvriss raised his sword and walked to one side of the street. Zel advanced on the other.

“Surrender now and we won’t kill you, traitor!”

Ilvriss roared at the other mage. The Drake smiled, his face glowing in the light from his staff.

“My duty is to keep you here. Or kill you. I think I can, no matter what I have been told about you, Shivertail.”

He raised his staff and pointed. Zel had been waiting for this moment and dove to one side. He felt something burn his leg and rolled upright. Ilvriss was charging the mage. He stepped onto the first rune and the ground *exploded*.

“*Ilvriss!*”

The Lord of the Wall charged through the smoke, one of his amulets shining like the sun. More wards exploded around him and he lunged at Imenet, too fast for the mage to dodge. His blade cut into the other Drake’s stomach—

And Imenet vanished. The illusion that had been him faded and Zel cursed. He looked around and heard Imenet’s voice everywhere.

“Warriors are such simple creatures. They shoot arrows, swing a sword—what can you do against illusions? Without magic, nothing. You are nothing, Zel Shivertail.”

Something—Zel turned, and the Drake [Mage] appeared. This time, the fireball blasted Zel straight in the chest. He vanished, and Imenet grinned as

the explosion of fire destroyed half the street.

Someone walked through the flames. A claw sliced through the second illusion of Imenet. Zel coughed and felt the fire and his melted breastplate burning his scales. They burned, like putting his claws on a hot kettle or a stovetop. He coughed, looking around for the [Mage].

“You may be right. We warriors don’t have the same tricks mages do. But we don’t die easily, either.”

Ilvriss was cursing, raising one of his rings and shouting into it. Screams echoed from the burning building. Zel heard a child’s voice. He waited, his blood boiling.

The Drake [Mage] reappeared at the other end of the street, no longer smiling. He stared at Zel.

“...That’s cheating.”

Zel didn’t reply back. He charged, and Imenet began casting spells at both Ilvriss and Zel. The night was full of death. Zel prayed the Gold-rank adventurers could handle Regrika Blackpaw. Imenet was far too strong to be merely Gold-rank. He had to hope that they could defeat her, Named Adventurer or not.

He roared as he charged and Imenet’s eyes grew wide. The mage turned and vanished. A Golem rose, shaping itself out of the flagstones and broken earth. Zel sunk a claw into its side and ripped a chunk of it away. He should have been fighting Blackpaw. She was too strong. That was what his [Dangersense] was telling him. Too strong for Gold-rank adventurers.

Far too strong.

Erin had seen Gazi Pathseeker fight, once. She had deflected arrows from every angle, fought a group of Guardsmen and not taken a single scratch. That was what made her a Named Adventurer. In Regrika’s case, it was not her sight. It was her limitless, contemptuous strength.

She could not be stopped. Her sword bit through a table Seborn was using as cover and the [Rogue] leapt. She slashed at his back and the Drowned Man *blurred*, using a Skill to get out of range in time. Moore swung his staff and Regrika raised her shield to block. She slashed, and he blocked.

The impact of sword meeting staff was thunder in the common room of the inn. Moore's huge arms strained and he grunted from the impact. He jabbed at Regrika with his staff, and she dodged the blow. She opened up his arm with one cut. He cried out, a loud, painful voice.

"Moore!"

Someone shouted his name. Regrika turned and Erin stared, holding a chair in her hands, about to throw. Jelaqua Ivirith charged into Regrika from behind, her flail's two heads spinning into the Gnoll's back. The top of Jelaqua's head from her eyebrows up was *gone*, but the Selphid moved as if she were entirely whole. No blood ran from her wound. And the inside of the head was...empty.

"Selphids."

That was all Regrika said. She backhanded Jelaqua with her shield and sent the Selphid tumbling backwards, unconscious. Moore was backed into a wall. He tensed as she turned, and thrust his staff into the ground.

A wall of earth shot up, breaking the floorboards and blocking him from Regrika. She slashed through the earth, sending it spraying and found—

A hole. Moore crashed *through* the wall, spraying glass and wood as he leapt into the snow outside. The Gnoll laughed. She whirled, and a fireball engulfed her in an explosion. When she appeared out of the smoke her shield was raised.

And she was unharmed.

"Dead gods take it all!"

Typhenous screamed and then paled as he realized Regrika was running towards him. He raised his staff.

"Halrac! [Astral Binding]!"

Shimmering ties of light shot out and constricted Regrika. For a moment. She tore through them and found Typhenous rushing for the door. She ran after him.

“Stop.”

Two arrows broke on her back. Regrika’s fur burned. A bit of lightning crackled over her armor. She turned her head and smiled at Halrac.

“You cannot harm me. I am perfection.”

A pot bounced off the back of her head. Halrac stood up, six feet away from Regrika. His eyes were burning as he pulled an arrow with a black tip from his quiver and set it to his bow.

“I will kill you.”

“Try.”

She lunged at him. Erin screamed as Halrac dodged sideways. Like Seborn he used a Skill—but it wasn’t enough. The sword missed, but Regrika kicked him as he passed. The impact sent Halrac crashing into one wall. Erin heard his ribs break.

“No! *No, no, no! Stop!*”

She charged Regrika with a knife. She heard Seborn shout at her. She didn’t care. The knife slashed at Regrika’s arm as the Gnoll looked at her. It felt as though Erin were cutting at a rock. Her kitchen knife did no damage to the Gnoll.

Erin knew it wouldn’t. Nothing she’d thrown had worked. Halrac’s arrows hadn’t worked. So she dropped the knife and clenched a fist.

“*[Minotaur Punch]!*”

She threw it with all her strength. Regrika’s face was almost too high for Erin to reach. Her fist struck the Gnoll’s chin and Erin felt the impact travel down her arm. Regrika stared down at her.

And smiled.

Pain. Erin felt as though she had hit a rock. She raised her left arm and punched again.

“*[Minotaur Punch]!*”

A second blow. This time Erin felt and heard something *crunch* in her hands. She didn't care. She punched again.

"[Minotaur Punch]! [Minotaur Punch]! [*Minotaur—*]"

Her right hand broke. Erin cried out as she felt her fingers break. Blood seeped through her torn skin. And Regrika stood in front of her. Unhurt. She raised both her arms upwards and stood tall. Her bloody sword and shield pointed towards the ceiling as the Gnoll posed.

Like a statue. She let Erin hit her, cut at her, ignoring her. Smiling. Seborn appeared behind her and slashed. His knives dug into her arm, cutting. Regrika stood through it all and then looked down at Erin. Her eyes were contemptuous.

"Insignificant."

The room was emptying. Moore had vanished. Typhenous had fled. Seborn vanished as Regrika turned away from Erin. The girl was crying, her hands dripping with blood. Regrika was unharmed save for a bloodless cut on her legs and scratches on the rest of her body. She looked around for her next victim and found him standing across the inn, next to the door.

Halrac's bow was raised. He had a single arrow drawn to his chest. His eyes were locked on Regrika.

"[Piercing Shot]."

The arrow struck her in the chest as Regrika covered her face, slipping underneath her guard. There was a *crack* that made Erin's ears ring. The arrow that hit Regrika did not explode, or break, or do anything else. But it pierced Regrika's armor. It buried itself halfway into her chest.

The Gnoll blinked down at the arrow. Halrac lowered his bow, staring. There was no blood coming from her wound. And Regrika didn't seem hurt, just surprised. She stared at the arrow and slowly drew it out of her. It snapped in her hands and she touched the hole in her chest.

Bloodless. But it had broken her armor. When she looked up, Regrika's smile was gone. Her eyes were filled with fury.

"You *hurt* me. *Me!*"

Halrac's second arrow was explosive. As the Gnoll lunged, the force of it blew Erin off her feet. She got up, ears ringing. Regrika's armor *cracked*. The metal fractured slightly from the explosion. Erin stared. Did metal do that?

The Gnoll *screamed* in fury and charged Halrac. He dove towards the open door. She charged after him.

"Halrac!"

Erin tried to go after him. Her hands were nothing but pain, but she had to do something!

"Don't go after him! Help me up!"

Someone shouted at her from behind. Erin turned. Who had spoken? Jelaqua was passed out on the ground. Seborn had vanished. Moore and Typhenous had fled and Halrac was running too. Then who—

A hand shot up. Erin stared in horror. Revi's arm moved as her head turned towards Erin. That was one part of her torso. Her other arm and the rest of her body lay on the ground, cleanly separated by Regrika's blade.

"Don't just stand there you idiot! *Help me* before that monster comes back!"

That broke the paralysis. Erin rushed over to Revi. All of the Stitch-Girl's summoned minions were gone, destroyed by Regrika, but their armor and weapons lay scattered around her. Revi's head looked up at Erin. There was pain in her eyes, but she still spoke.

"Sew me up! There's a needle in my pockets. Don't worry about neatness, just get me together. Now!"

"But how—I thought—"

"You can't kill a Stitch-Girl with a sword! Hurry! Halrac's running for his life. If that Gnoll catches him—"

Erin fumbled for Revi's pocket. She stabbed the needle deep into her finger when she found it, and barely noticed the pain. Her right hand was useless. Her left...Revi cursed at her as Erin clumsily pulled one of the threads through the needle. Each second felt like forever.

"Hurry, hurry, *hurry!* If she comes back—"

A heavy tread. Erin froze and Revi's eyes went wide. Regrika appeared in the doorway, smiling. Only this time fury was in her eyes.

"Clever. The rats have fled. They jumped down a hole in the snow. Into a dungeon. But you? You're still here. And I can kill you."

She pointed at Revi. The [Summoner] went very pale. One of her hands grabbed Erin's needle and began to stitch the rest of her body together as Erin rose.

"I won't let—"

Regrika shoved Erin aside. Erin grabbed at her, trying to pull her back. Her feet skidded across the broken floor as Regrika walked over to Revi. The Stitch-Girl was nearly complete, but she still couldn't move her lower half. She looked up, eyes full of fear. Regrika grinned.

"Please step away from the guest."

Someone spoke. Regrika whirled and stared. Erin turned. A figure was standing in the doorway with a drawn bow. For a second Erin's mind saw Halrac, and then the figure moved and she realized it wasn't him.

It was Bird. Two of his arms held the bow, his other two held something in his hands. He was alone, and he stared at Regrika. She stared back.

"An Antinium?"

He nodded.

"I am Bird. I am a guard at the inn."

The Gnoll smiled.

"A dead one. You should have fled."

"I was asleep."

The Gnoll blinked. Bird looked past her and at Erin.

"I was asleep in my tower. I woke up to hunt birds. I assume that this person is a danger to you and or the residents of your inn?"

Erin stared at him. Regrika stared at him. Revi took the moment to keep stitching her torso together. The Antinium waited and then turned to Regrika.

“Know that I am obliged to hurt you with brutal force. You are not a bird, so I will shoot you and not eat you. Unless you are tasty.”

The Gnoll stared at him. Then she began to walk towards him. Bird loosed the arrow. It *snapped* as it struck her between the eyes. The Antinium paused.

“Ah. I saw that happen earlier too. I woke up and watched the battle, by the way.”

“You cannot harm me.”

Regrika’s voice was arrogance, her stride lazy as she crossed the inn towards the Antinium. Bird nodded.

“I noticed. This is my tactical analysis of what I should do in a situation like this.”

His other two hands rose. They were holding something. A bucket. Bird hurled it at Regrika. She didn’t block it. The dark liquid splashed over her and Regrika stopped. Erin froze. She couldn’t see well in the darkness, but she could *smell* it. Bird turned.

“That was feces from the outhouse. I gathered it. It is an antagonistic action meant to irritate. I am bait. The poo is not from birds, by the way.”

He ran out the door. Regrika was staring at the excrement covering her body. She brushed off a clump, and then she went insane.

“You have disgraced my image! You! I will kill you!”

She rushed out the door. Erin turned to Revi. The Stitch-Girl shouted at her.

“Hurry! I can’t reach my back!”

This time Erin plunged the needle into the cloth as fast as she could. When the last clumsy stitch was in place, the cloth lower half became real. Revi gasped, sat up.

“We have to run. Where’s the back door?”

“I don’t have one!”

“The hole, then. Corusdeer!”

She raised the bit of horn in her hands and a spectral deer cantered into focus. Revi leapt onto its back and extended a hand.

“Come on! We’re dead if she comes back!”

“I can’t. I can’t run away from her! She killed—”

Erin choked on the words. She killed Brunkr. And Ulrien. Revi slapped her.

“You can’t save anyone if you’re dead! Come *on!*”

“She won’t hurt me. I don’t think she can. I don’t know why.”

Erin replied numbly. It wasn’t just her instincts that were telling her this. Regrika had ignored her several times. Erin didn’t know why, but she felt certain that she was safe. She, and she alone.

Revi opened her mouth, and then paused. There was *crunching* outside, the same footfalls. She paled and the summoned Corusdeer swung around. Revi shot through the hole Moore had made. Erin turned.

Regrika walked back through the doorway. She stank. Her eyes were blazing, but there was no broken chitin on her blade or the Antinium’s green blood. Erin stared at Regrika. The Gnoll paused as she stepped through the broken inn. She looked around for Revi and then at Erin.

“I will remember you. And I will come back. I will slaughter all those who were here. The mages, the Selphid, the [Scout] and the Antinium. They will all suffer.”

“Who are you?”

Erin spoke quietly. She looked Regrika in the eye. The Gnoll laughed.

“I was sent here by my master for one reason. To kill Ryoka Griffin.”

She turned to the door leading to Celum. Erin felt her heart stop. She blocked Regrika’s way. The Gnoll shoved Erin aside.

“Stop! No! You can’t!”

Erin battered at her, but again, it was useless. She tried to pull Regrika back with her good hand. It was impossible. She grabbed onto the Gnoll’s leg, tried to pull her back using a table as an anchor. The table *jerked* across the ground and Erin felt her arm being pulled out of its socket. Regrika

didn't slow. She opened the door and looked down at Erin as the girl clung to her with all her strength.

"I do not see why he values you. You are pathetic. And you cannot stop me. No one can."

She bent and contemptuously prised Erin's hand from her leg without effort. Then she stepped through the door to Celum. It swung shut behind her.

And then she was gone.

The fight in the inn had taken less than half an hour. Celum was quiet when Venitra strode out of Octavia's alchemy shop, smashing through her window without bothering to use the door. Those who were on the streets did not pay much attention to the Gnoll until they saw her bloody sword and raised the alarm.

In Liscor, the night was broken by shouts and howling. Zel Shivertail dove to the side as a bolt of crackling *red* lightning shot down the street, nearly missing him. The electricity arced and struck his breastplate, making him hiss, but most of the energy grounded itself harmlessly on a metal railing of one of the houses.

"Ancestors damn it! Where the hell *is* he?"

Zel roared at a Drake taking cover behind him. Ilvriss glared and raised his sword as he peeked around the side of a wall.

"I don't know! My amulet has a radius of about ten feet. I can't search while that traitor's blasting me with spells!"

The two Drakes ducked as another spell—a boulder thrown by magic—crashed near their position. Zel looked around. The street was a disaster area, and Imenet was standing in the center of it, raining spells down on their position.

Only, it wasn't Imenet. There was another Drake mage with purple scales standing on a rooftop, and another in the doorway of a building. The

[Mage] had created multiple copies of himself, all illusions, and it was impossible to tell which was which.

“They might all be illusions out there! We need a [Mage] to dispel the illusions or we’ll be chasing our tails until that bastard gets us! Where’s the Watch? Where are your helpers?”

Zel shouted at Ilvriss. The Lord of the Wall cursed.

“Behind one of the walls, or fighting one of the Golems that was summoned! We have to either break an opening or—*incoming!*”

Both Drakes had heard the whistling noise at the same time. They abandoned their hiding spot as a boulder fell down from above. Imenet pointed and Zel saw more hovering boulders in the sky. The Drake [Mage] had figured out that spells were ineffectual against both Zel and Ilvriss and had decided to crush them instead.

Ilvriss’ rings flared as he caught a bolt of red-lightning. He shouted as he charged the [Mage] and his sword cut through the illusionary Imenet. Again. Zel cursed and looked for somewhere else to hide. They couldn’t kill the mage and he was trying to cut off their space. Sooner or later he’d be hit, and when that happened, there *were* ways to kill him, even with his resistance to spells.

And in the meantime, people were dying. Imenet’s spells had burned one building. People had leapt to their deaths rather than die in the blaze. His other spells were blasting holes in the city. Two of the summoned constructs were battling the Watch. As Ilvriss and Zel met up again, crawling under a collapsed building, Zel spotted an arm buried in the rubble. It had scales, yellow, covered in dust. And it was far too small.

It was too much. He was a [General of the Line], a protector of his people. And they were dying while he took cover. Zel clenched his fist.

“We’re ending this now, Ilvriss. I’ll distract him. You try and locate the mage with your amulet. I’ll take on his spells.”

“Are you insane, Shivertail? He won’t bother with magic—he’ll crush you!”

“I’ll dodge. People are dying, Ilvriss.”

The Lord of the Wall hesitated. Then he nodded.

“Don’t die.”

Zel nodded. He walked out from behind his cover. All of the projections of Imenet looked at him.

“Giving up, Zel Shivertail?”

“Give me your best shot, mage.”

The Drake bared his teeth. His tail lashed the ground as he saw Imenet pointing. The levitating boulders angled themselves towards him. Then Imenet paused. All of his projections suddenly looked left. Zel looked as well, and saw blue.

Her carapace shone in the moonlight. It sparkled. Unlike the other Antinium with their brown bodies, the pigmentation of Xrn’s body had a luster of its own. It was surpassed only by her eyes. They shone green and blue and red, colors mixing together and swirling in the darkness.

“The Small Queen.”

Imenet inhaled. His illusions shifted their grip on their staffs, suddenly nervous. Zel stared warily at Xrn. She had a staff of her own. She raised her other hand in greeting.

“Zel Shivertail. I did not expect to see you here. But this situation makes more sense the more I see.”

“Why are *you* here? This doesn’t concern you. This Drake is your enemy.”

Imenet’s voice sounded worried and panicked by turns. Xrn looked at him. He raised his staff threateningly. She only nodded towards the devastation around her.

“I thought I sensed someone casting destructive magic. Klbkch refused to believe me at first, but he is on his way with many Soldiers.”

Zel wasn’t sure if he should be relieved or worried. Imenet was certainly unhappy. He shifted, staring at the ground, and then glared at Xrn.

“I have no quarrel with you, Antinium. Stand aside and I will rid your people of Zel Shivertail. Get in my way and I will destroy you.”

His words made Zel tense. Imenet was clearly his enemy. But Xrn was an unknown quantity. If she teamed up with him—

The Small Queen regarded Imenet with a tilted head. She sighed.

“You killed children and innocents with your spells. You, a Drake. I do not understand it. The Antinium are called monsters because we sacrifice our own. But we do not murder each other.”

Both Imenet and Zel stared at her. Xrn turned her head away from the image of Imenet she was staring at and began talking to the air next to her.

“My orders from the Grand Queen are not to use force unless attacked first. Especially not against groups like adventurers to avoid starting a war. So I will not cast any spells. Unless you hit me with one. Please, do.”

The Drake shifted his grip on the staff. He didn’t move. Xrn nodded. Zel looked at her warily. If she wasn’t going to fight, but just stand there—

Stand there. Xrn was speaking and staring at a blank patch of...nothing, although she’d clearly been addressing Imenet. She was staring at it intently. Zel’s heart pounded. He abandoned his position and *charged* towards Xrn. Not at her, but a bit to the left. At the patch of air.

The [General] rushed past Xrn. She didn’t budge. His claws opened and he aimed for the exact spot where she’d been looking. For a second he thought nothing was there, and then he heard a sound. *Something* cursed and shifted. Zel lashed out. His claws were sharper than steel and he caught something—

Imenet appeared, stumbling, his side laid open, but bloodless. He glared at Zel and spoke.

“[Lesser Teleport]!”

He vanished. Zel whirled around, saw nothing. He stared back at Xrn. She glanced at him, and then casually stared up. Zel looked up and saw her gaze was on a rooftop two buildings over.

“Lovely night, isn’t it?”

He didn’t respond. Zel charged towards the building. Halfway there he heard a cough. Xrn’s gaze was now on a building collapsed by rubble. Ilvriss ran towards Zel, sword drawn.

“The Ant’s looking—?”

“That’s right.”

Zel grinned and Ilvriss stared at Xrn before gripping his sword with both hands. The Drakes advanced. Zel muttered to Ilvriss.

“Hard target. I felt like I was cutting into armor, not flesh. Go for limb amputations and use force.”

“Got it.”

They circled the rubble. Nothing was there. Ilvriss gripped at his amulet. There was a *flash*, and Imenet blurred into place. For a second Zel thought he saw something else, something black and shiny—but then the Drake shot up. He threw fire at both Drakes, retreating. He vanished as Ilvriss leapt at him, sword swinging.

“This isn’t *fair*!”

“Life seldom is.”

Xrn carefully turned her head, staring at an open patch of ground across the street. Both Zel and Ilvriss charged. This time Imenet raised his staff and Ilvriss threw something. There was a *screech* and whatever spell the Drake was trying to use failed. Zel and Ilvriss tore into him from both sides.

Zel ripped part of the mage’s arm away, slicing through...something hard. Ilvriss grunted as he cut through the mage’s leg. Imenet fell, grabbing at his leg. He wasn’t bleeding.

“Got him!”

Ilvriss put a foot on the mage’s chest and ran him through. He twisted the sword, pulled it out, and stabbed it in again. The body beneath him convulsed, and then the corpse, the thing that *should* have been a corpse, muttered a spell.

“[Aerial Burst].”

Both Drakes flew backwards. Xrn raised her staff and held her ground, a bubble of violet light appearing around her. Imenet got up, holding his leg, using his staff for support. He was babbling, and his voice was...changed. It was suddenly feminine, and echoed slightly.

“I’m going to die. Me. Oh no. Master, help, help...!”

Zel ran at him...her? Imenet turned to him, and there was genuine fear on his face. Zel slashed at his head, and felt a connection. Then there was light. Imenet vanished.

“Damn!”

Zel roared and spun to Xrn. She was looking around. She shook her head.

“Nowhere. He vanished. I could have sworn I felt someone else’s magic there. That was a powerful teleportation spell, far beyond what he could have used. An artifact? Hm. Shivertail, why was that Drake trying to kill you?”

“No time. Ilvriss! The inn!”

Zel roared. Ilvriss pulled himself out of a collapsed wall, swearing. The two Drakes raced for one of the walls Imenet had raised. They got over it after Xrn blew a hole in it for them to cross. They found two destroyed Earth Golems, at least sixty [Guardsmen], Watch Captain Zevara, and an army of Antinium Soldiers behind them.

“Hey, it’s General Zel!”

One of the Guardsmen, Relc, called out. He had a spear in hand and he was standing on top of one of the fallen Golems. He leapt down as Klbkch and Zevara both strode towards them. Zevara’s eyes flicked towards Xrn. She looked warily at Klbkch.

“General Shivertail? Is the Antinium—?”

“No. We were attacked by Imenet. He and Regrika Blackpaw are murderers. I have reason to believe they killed Brunkr. We were teleported here and Regrika is back at the inn!”

The Drake’s eyes widened. She looked at Zel, and then towards the gates.

“Regrika Blackpaw? But—”

“I want everyone with a level higher than twenty at that inn, *now!* Erin Solstice and two Gold-rank teams are there, but a Named Adventurer might be too much for them.”

“Erin? Wait, what’s—”

“The inn! *Go!*”

Zel roared it at the confused people around him. Relc’s eyes widened. He turned and began sprinting down the streets. Klbkch was already pointing and shouting. Antinium streamed out of the city, and Zel ran after them. They found Revi and Bird fleeing towards them. And in the inn—

Death. And no Regrika. She was already in Celum. And by that point, they were too late to catch her.

Venitra strode through the city of Celum, blade at the ready, closing in on Ryoka Griffin’s position. She knew where the Human girl was exactly, thanks to the magic Ijvani had cast. The Humans in the streets cried out and ran when they saw her approaching with blood splattered across her armor. Venitra cared not.

She was unstoppable. The Gold-rank adventurers had damaged her. *Her*. And the Antinium had—*soiled*—her form. The form her master had given her! Venitra had burned him into her memory. She would tear him apart slowly. But she had a mission. It trumped all things.

Ryoka was in a little inn called the Frenzied Hare. Venitra strode through the door, hearing conversations stop. She spotted the Runner at a table with four other adventurers. The Horns of Hammerad looked up. They froze when they saw Venitra, or rather, Regrika Blackpaw covered in blood. Ryoka slowly got up, her eyes wide.

“Miss Blackpaw, what’s—”

Venitra lunged. Her sword shot across the table towards Ryoka. The Human—dodged. She twisted in her seat and threw herself across Yvlon’s lap. As Regrika cursed, she cut left. She was trying to cut straight through Yvlon, but her sword slashed across the woman’s breastplate instead. Yvlon shouted and Ryoka ran for the door.

“Come back here and die, Ryoka Griffin!”

The undead woman roared, not caring that she was ruining her guise as Regrika Blackpaw. She was too incensed to care. Ryoka disappeared out the door in a blur. Venitra ran after her and felt something slowing her. She looked down.

Ice was covering her lower half. She saw Ceria pointing, and walls of ice rose in front of the undead woman, blocking her way. Venitra raised her shield and punched through the wall of ice, shattering it. She swung her sword and the ice binding her broke.

“Stop!”

The Horns of Hammerad spread out around Venitra, looking afraid, but determined. Venitra longed to cut them all down, but she ran for the door. Ryoka was more important.

“You are attacking our comrade. I would advise you to surrender, Named Adventurer or n—”

Her shield smashed into Ksmvr as he tried to bar her way. The Antinium fell. Yvlon lunged for Venitra, sword flashing.

She had no *time* for this! Venitra ignored Yvlon’s sword and accessed a part of her she seldom used. Her master had done more than create her body. He had imbued her with certain enchantments.

“[Mists of Madness].”

The spell erupted from her body in the form of a cloud which engulfed the inn and spilled out onto the street. She heard the other adventurers shout, and then the inn went insane. The cowering Humans suddenly turned on each other, some clawing at each other’s faces, others grabbing weapons and hitting each other, themselves—some sat in corners and gibbered, or became different people.

“A simple matter.”

Venitra strode out of the inn, sensing which way Ryoka had gone. She began to run as the insanity-causing mists began to affect the entire street. The [Guardsmen] who’d come running became crazed killers themselves.

Venitra. What is taking you so long?

Her master's voice. Venitra cowered internally as she ran.

"I am pursuing Ryoka Griffin right now, master! I was delayed but she cannot escape—"

The Runner was moving fast. Venitra was faster. She barreled *through* the wall of a building and out the other side. Ryoka turned, eyes wide, and reversed direction as she ran down a street. Venitra ran after her. Az'kerash's voice thundered in her head.

Where? No—I see by the spell you are close. Hurry, Venitra. Ijvani has retreated due to her wounds. Ryoka must not escape!

"Yes, master! I am almost—"

Someone stabbed Venitra in the back. She paused, turned, and lashed out with her sword. There was a blur of motion and her sword cut through air. She saw the blur resolve itself into a figure standing several feet away. He had a flaming rapier in his hand and crackling magic lightning in the other.

Pisces coughed, waving away the madness-causing mists that still clung to his robe. He was frowning, but the spell hadn't affected him. He smiled weakly and nodded to Venitra.

"A mental attack is only half as efficacious on the second attempt. I am afraid...I have already experienced my own insane delusions once."

His rapier was at the ready. His stance was set, his eyes watchful. Venitra turned away in disgust. As she did, Pisces blurred forwards and stabbed her in her arm. He seemed astonished when his rapier did nothing but slide off Venitra's bone body.

"Begone, pest!"

She lashed out at him. Pisces blurred away, using the [Flash Step] spell. She turned to run, and he appeared next to her, rapier dancing across her side. Stab, stab, *cut*. Three precise strikes, all failures. Then he vanished. Venitra roared in Regrika's voice, irritated by his futile attacks.

Venitra, stop paying attention to him and pursue Ryoka Griffin!

Her master's voice made Venitra turn and immediately begin running. Pisces struck her twice more in the back as she did, and then blasted her face with lightning. Venitra swung her sword, trying to catch him, but he was a gnat, buzzing around her, too quick to catch!

But he could not harm her either. His rapier, enchanted with magical flames, was weak, and his spells were laughable. Venitra had been enchanted to withstand spells from Named Adventurers! She could not be so easily—

“[Bone Fracture].”

A hand on her arm. A sensation. Venitra felt her arm, cut slightly by Seborn's knives, *crack*. She stopped and stared down in horror at her arm. Running along her perfectly shaped arm was the tiniest, most miniscule of breaks. She stared at Pisces. He disappeared as her shield swung at his head. He appeared at the other end of the street. He stared at her.

“You are no Gnoll. What...what *are* you? Who made you?”

He knew. In that moment, Venitra knew he had to die. She ran at him. Pisces became a blur, dodging away. He was faster than Ryoka Griffin thanks to his magic!

“You will not escape!”

Venitra roared at him. She tapped into the enchantments on her body, about to use another one. Her master's voice halted her.

Hold, Venitra. Ryoka Griffin is getting away.

“But master, he *knows*!”

So I have witnessed. I will deal with him. He is...different. Hunt down Ryoka Griffin, now!

Her master's words were never wrong. Venitra turned. She saw Pisces appear in front of her. He raised his hand, about to use the spell again, when his eyes went wide. He touched his hand to his head.

“Who is speaking to me? Who—?”

Venitra ran past him. She envied Pisces. He was speaking to her master. There could be no higher honor. She ran down the street, no longer hampered by anything or anyone. Venitra ran straight to Ryoka Griffin, charging through walls, running over anyone she encountered in the street. The Runner was too slow to evade her.

She burst through a wall and there was Ryoka Griffin. The Runner's eyes widened and she turned. Too slow this time. Venitra's hand shot out and she grabbed Ryoka's arm. Then her face.

“I have you now.”

Venitra's fingers tightened on Ryoka's head as the young woman lashed at her chest, punching, kicking. Venitra felt nothing but satisfaction as she tightened her grip. Then she remembered her master's injunction and stopped before she fractured Ryoka's skull.

But her arms. Venitra could start with them. She seized Ryoka's arm and grabbed one of her fingers. She bent the pinkie finger of Ryoka's right hand back, *back*, and then tore it off. The girl screamed. It was the sound Venitra had waited for all this time.

Venitra, what are you doing?

She flinched as Ryoka convulsed in her grip. Venitra's voice was sulky, reticent.

“Master, I was only—”

I told you to *find* Ryoka Griffin, not waste time! You have disobeyed me once. Why are you wasting time with nothing when—

“Master? I have Ryoka Griffin!”

What was going on? Venitra stared at Ryoka. The girl was sobbing in her arms, blood running from her detached finger. Az’kerash’s voice paused in her mind.

What?

“I have Ryoka Griffin. In my hands.”

Venitra repeated herself slowly, disbelievingly. Was something wrong with her master’s spell? Inconceivable. And yet, he did not see Ryoka Griffin through her eyes. Either he was wrong or the spell was wrong. Either way, it was impossible.

Venitra. What are you looking at?

Az’kerash’s mental tone was slow, quiet. Venitra hesitated.

“Ryoka Griffin, master.”

No. You are not. There is nothing there.

The world paused. Venitra turned and stared at Ryoka Griffin’s face. She saw tears in the girl’s eyes, an anguished face—and then a smile. Ryoka straightened. She looked Venitra in the eye and laughed as her hand bled and Venitra held her pinkie. Then she spoke.

“What? Did ye think she’d really sit here and wait for death? More the fool ye art, then.”

The girl blurred in front of Venitra. Her finger and body vanished. Something blue and indistinct hovered in front of Venitra's face. She stared at it.

And her master lost his temper.

“Where is she? *Find her!*”

Az'kerash's voice was never raised. His wrath was cold and deliberate, never a product of emotion. That made this moment and his raised voice all the more terrible now. He paced back and forth in his castle, staring at the image of Celum as Venitra ran through it. His servants cowered. Ijvani, her skull fractured and her black metal bones torn and broken in many places, flinched as she bent over an orb.

They were scrying for Ryoka Griffin. The spell that she had cast had been—altered—somehow. It pointed to the Winter Sprite. But Ryoka Griffin was elsewhere. They had to find her.

“There.”

It wasn't Ijvani who spoke, but the other spellcaster among Az'kerash's chosen. Bea. The rotting woman turned to their master, an image of Ryoka Griffin in her hands. She was running through the snow, the world racing around her.

Az'kerash, the Necromancer, reacted at once. He closed his eyes and put one delicate finger to his brow. When he spoke, it was to Venitra, hundreds of miles away from their location.

“Venitra, your quarry is southeast of Celum. She is heading towards...”

He paused.

“Towards the High Passes? No. That cannot be—*catch her*, Venitra! Use the [Haste] spell, now!”

Ijvani did not hear the reply, but in the image of Venitra that was being projected to her in her orb, she saw Regrika Blackpaw suddenly blur and

race out of the city. She closed the connection and flinched as her master turned towards her.

“Master, I am sorry. I failed—”

“You did little wrong, Ijvani. Against Zel Shivertail and a Lord of the Wall, I would not expect you to triumph. Let alone with the Small Queen interfering. Why did she help Shivertail? How would that serve the Antinium? Why is a Winter Sprite—”

He broke off. Ijvani shrank, feeling her broken form leaking mana. Zel had cut through her ribs with his claws, and the Drake with the sword had cut off her leg! It didn’t hurt of course, but the loss of one of her limbs was painful in a mental way.

Far worse was seeing her master distressed. Ijvani looked around the room. All of her master’s servants in the castle were here. Oom, dark, wearing a long trench coat and hat, face obscured. Bea, rotting, rotten. Lovely in her putrefaction. And Kerash. He was an undead Gnoll, a giant among his kind even in death. He was as tall as Venitra and proud. And dead.

All of them bowed their heads as Az’kerash strode past them. His black eyes and white pupils were narrowed in his ire.

“Shivertail. He may suspect. Ijvani, your illusion broke down twice during the battle for a few moments. Besides that—this is too good an opportunity to waste. He is a thorn. I will have him removed.”

“Master? Do you wish me and Venitra to kill him?”

Ijvani wasn’t sure she could be of much help. The [General] had survived some of her best spells! Venitra might be able to kill him, but alone...Az’kerash shook his head.

“No. Venitra will catch Ryoka Griffin. I will not wait for her. I have used one of my scrolls of [Greater Teleportation]. I must spend more, it seems. Bea, Kerash, Oom. You three will accompany Ijvani. I will teleport you all—you will each carry a scroll of [Greater Teleportation] with you.”

His servants held their breaths. Well, none of them needed to breathe, even Oom, so that was figurative. But they were all astonished. The scrolls of [Greater Teleportation] were limited. Even their master could not acquire

more. And four, one for each of them? They stared at their master as Az'kerash spoke.

"You will appear in Liscor and kill Shivertail and as many Antinium and Drakes as possible. Bea, I leave the slaughter of Antinium and lesser soldiers to you. Ijvani, you will support Kerash in disposing of the dangerous elements, such as the Gold-rank adventurers. Oom, you were created to deal with enemies like Zel Shivertail. Kill him without giving him any opportunity to run."

"Yes, master."

They bowed as one and lined up before their master. Az'kerash walked past them. Kerash, axe in hand. Bea, smiling. Oom, faceless. And Ijvani, wounded but eyes alight with power. He nodded and glanced back towards one of the images of Liscor. In it, shapes milled about, soldiers rushing towards the inn.

"You will teleport in as a group. Try to catch Shivertail alone. He is surrounded by too many strong individuals for an open engagement. The long-distance teleportation spell will take thirty minutes to complete; possibly longer...I will not waste *eight* scrolls. As for the battle, if you believe yourself in danger, return here with the scroll rather than risk yourselves. I have need of you all. None of you are permitted to die."

They shivered in delight. They were needed. Their master needed them. He began to trace a complicated pattern on the floor, glowing lines spreading out as he pointed. Az'kerash began to calculate their destination, lips moving slowly. Because he was their master, he could speak and act while he cast the spell.

"A last note. The innkeeper. I do not know where she will be when you appear. But if she becomes a casualty...I will understand. Zel Shivertail's death matters above all. After he dies, you will regroup. The Slayer is there, as is the Small Queen. And one of the Antinium Queens. If I must reveal part of my forces in some form tonight, I will reap the rewards of it. However, I intend to keep my secret. Kill all witnesses. Is that clear?"

"Yes master."

They spoke as one. And watched as the image of Ryoka Griffin fleeing grew closer to the image of Venitra. They were both running through the

snow. And no one could catch either one.

Time was running out for Ryoka. And for Zel Shivertail, and Liscor.

Ryoka ran. The snow blurred around her. Her legs churned through the ice, biting into the packed snow. She was barefoot. Her feet bled as they landed on shards of ice. She wore no jacket, no long pants. She was in shorts and t-shirt.

This was the fastest way she could move. Ryoka ran, and felt her legs and body freezing. She was bleeding, leaving a crimson trail in the snow.

Time. She fumbled at her belt. She had left her belt pouches behind, abandoned her bag of holding. But she had taken something with her. Vials of liquid. She grabbed one with frozen fingertips and removed the cork. The liquid sloshed and some splashed out into the snow. Ryoka ignored it and lifted the sparkling violet liquid up in one shaking hand.

She poured the potion into her mouth, choking as she tried to swallow and breathe at the same time. The liquid burned going down. And then the fire spread. Her frozen body began to warm. Ryoka felt her feet tingle and her toes began to feel once more. Her feet began to heal, the cuts closing.

A second potion, as she tossed the empty healing vial away. This one was green and made energy rush through Ryoka's frame. Her legs began to move quicker. The stamina potion reinvigorated her, healed the aching muscles, and gave her more energy to keep sprinting. Ryoka kept running, trying not to puke.

These were the eighth and ninth potions she'd downed. The side effects of so many potions were making her sick. She had vomited while running. Twice.

But she couldn't stop. Ryoka knew she'd been running for hours. Hours. The instant after she'd written her goodbye letter, she'd gone through the door to Celum, leaving a disguised Ivolethe behind.

Now the snow and dark night blew around her. It was dark. Ryoka couldn't tell how long she'd been running; only that it was too long. She had to hurry up. She had to get to the High Passes in time.

It took half a day of running to get there. Ryoka had to be there *faster*. She didn't know how long Ivolethe's disguise would last, or if she'd slip up when Venitra and Ijvani spoke to her. Would they know? And if they did, what would they do?

No choice. It was that or let them kill her friends one by one. Ryoka pumped her arms and legs, willing them to run faster. The mountains, the impossibly high peaks loomed in the darkness ahead. So close and too far.

Ryoka felt like she was running in slow motion. *Slow! So slow!* She'd seen Valceif run, seen Hawk run—even Relc was faster than she was! She had to go faster.

Or her friends would die. Erin would die. Mrsha and Lyonette would die. She had to run.

Something moved in the darkness. Ryoka flinched, expecting wolves, a traveler. But the glow was blue and familiar. She saw it streak ahead of her, and then saw Ivolethe's tiny form, flying, glowing ahead of her. And just like that, Ryoka knew she'd run out of time.

“Ivolethe!”

She screamed at the faerie, her breath snatched away by the breeze. The faerie looked back and Ryoka saw her flying ahead, flying through the wind. So quick, so effortless.

She did not speak. Of course not. She'd told Ryoka she was bending all the rules to play a prank like this. That it was a prank was the only reason she could get away. She couldn't help now.

It was just Ryoka. So the girl ran as fast and as hard as she ever had. She tried. She really did. She tried to run like the wind. She tried to run *with* the wind. But it blew in her face.

And the faerie flew on, looking back. Ryoka raced after her, trying. How did it go? *Step as if you want to walk into the sky. That is how faeries fly.*

But she was no faerie. She was mortal, afraid, weak. Ryoka felt sick. She tried to feel the wind. It was no good. She was trying, trying so hard! Why couldn't she do it? Why...why....?

Why was life so unfair? She was trying. But the wind blew and the snow chilled her. And then Ryoka heard the voice from behind.

“I am coming.”

It was a sound no mortal throat could make. No lungs could contain enough air, no mortal throat could make that sound. It echoed for miles, thundering. Fear made Ryoka run faster. She was coming. She was here.

Venitra.

There was a shape blurring through the snow behind Ryoka, in the distance, but moving incredibly fast. Venitra ran, magic making her move at twice, three times her normal speed. Ryoka despaired when she saw that. It wasn't fair! The bone woman ran towards her. Now her voice was louder.

“You cannot escape me.”

She had promised to kill Ryoka slowly. Kill her and everyone she loved. Ryoka felt her fingers breaking. She ran, pumping her legs. Too slow.

Ivolethe flew ahead of her, looking back. Ryoka thought she saw other faeries flying in the snow now. Or was it her delusion? The wind blew into her face. She chased the blue glow. But it was always ahead of her. And the magic—where was the magic?

It was never there when Ryoka needed it. She reached out, lungs burning, legs failing. Ivolethe was disappearing. But the faerie's tiny head was looking back, urging Ryoka on. Telling her to follow. To run like the wind.

But Ryoka couldn't. Tears froze on her face. She ran and whispered a word.

“Please.”

Her lungs burned. The word disappeared. Ivolethe's gaze was caught with hers. Too slow. Venitra appeared out of the blizzard and lunged.

“I have you!”

Her golden eyes burned. Ryoka swerved desperately, trying to avoid her. Venitra missed and Ryoka felt her powerful hands snap together where Ryoka’s neck would be. She ran, trying to lose the woman. But Venitra was too quick.

“You cannot escape me!”

Ryoka grabbed at her belt pouch and threw a bag. It turned into vines as thick as her legs, tangling around Venitra. The undead roared and tore the Tripvine bag away in moments. She caught up with Ryoka in another.

“You cannot get away!”

One step. Two. Ryoka ran and tried to run into the sky. She ran after that tantalizing glow, that bit of blue magic in the storm.

She failed. Venitra seized hold of her. Her arms were tight on Ryoka’s neck.

“Now who will save you? No one.”

Her words ran together, almost too quick to follow, a product of the [Haste] spell. Ryoka closed her eyes. Waiting. Venitra dropped Ryoka and seized hold of her arm. Ryoka twisted, trying to run as one of her fingers was seized in an iron grip. She looked for Ivolethe. She’d always thought the faerie would protect her! But there was no Ivolethe. One of Ryoka’s fingers bent. It snapped.

She screamed. The second was caught. Again. And then Ryoka did scream.

“Ivolethe!”

There was no flash of blue in the blizzard. No sign of her at all. She could not help. Venitra laughed. A third finger was gripped, and Ryoka stared around. But the faerie had not come for her. She and her sisters were gone. There was no blue.

But there was green. A flash moved past Ryoka in the snow. She blinked and then she heard a voice.

“[Relc Kick]!”

A foot smashed into Venitra's head. She blinked and let go of Ryoka. The girl dropped and Relc appeared. He stared at the Gnoll Named Adventurer and then at Ryoka.

"Run, you idiot! I thought you were supposed to be *fast*!"

Ryoka got to her feet. She ran. Relc faced Regrika Blackpaw as the Gnoll stared at him. She had her sword and shield. He had a wooden spear with a steel tip, solid, thick, and unenchanted. She struck at him. He leapt backwards.

"Whoa! That's a [Haste] spell! You cheating bastard!"

The Human girl ran through the snow. The High Passes were ahead. Venitra, Regrika, hesitated. She turned. A spear tip caught her in the back of the head. Relc yelped.

"What the *hell*? What's your head made of? Rocks?"

She turned and ran, blurring after Ryoka. Too fast for the Runner to evade or outrun. Regrika was nearly on top of Ryoka when she heard a shout.

"[Lightning Sprint]! [Triple Thrust]!"

A shape moved past her, fast, *faster* than she was. Three spears seemed to appear at once, striking Regrika in the face, side, and arm. She turned, swung her sword. Relc dodged back again, panting.

"Okay, seriously. I'm retired, you know? And this is a lot faster than I'd like. Can't you, I dunno, *bleed*?"

She snarled at him. Relc snarled back. They fought in the snow. Regrika lunged at Relc, sword swinging. He dodged back, feinting, not willing to block her strikes. His spear shot out, was blocked by her armor, her shield. A thrust hit her in the face, glanced off.

"*This* is why I wanted my enchanted spear! But noooo—"

Relc yelped and zipped back a few steps as Regrika lunged again. He was panting hard now, his face greying with exhaustion. He held up a hand, chest heaving.

"Okay, okay, I may be a bit out of shape. And my Skills don't last forever. Why don't you...is that [Haste] spell expired yet?"

She charged at him. Relc struck her twice with his spear. She rammed forwards with her shield and he had to block. His spear *splintered* from the impact and he fell back. Relc stared at the bits of spear in his hand and then at Venitra. He curled a fist.

“[Relc Punch]! Relc Punch! Damn it, I could really use an actual Skill like that!”

He punched her twice as she swung at him. She caught his chest and laid it open with a strike. Relc cried out and ran, fumbling at his belt for a healing potion.

“Too old for this! Good luck, Runner Girl!”

Venitra let him go. She turned to the High Passes. In the distance, a girl was running through the snow. Goats were racing after her. Stone gargoyles stirred in their frozen nests. Venitra ran. She caught Ryoka five seconds later.

This was how it ended. Ivolethe closed her eyes as Venitra swung Ryoka bodily into a rock face. The girl cried out. Venitra turned and beheaded one of the fearless goats that were trying to bite her leg.

Her sisters floated in the air around Ivolethe. They chattered, some laughing, others mocking Ryoka. Some sympathized with the girl, others the undead bound by spells and loyalty to her master. Some cared. Others did not.

But Ivolethe alone knew the scene below mattered. She alone remembered Ryoka’s name. She alone called her friend.

But she had done too much. Too much. The rules had been bent, and trespassed in places. Ivolethe had done all she could. And it was not enough.

“Sister, sister. Do not interfere. Our King watches. He knows!”

One of her sisters, young and impetuous, cautioned Ivolethe. Another, old as time, spoke.

“It is not worth it. Not for her. Not for a mortal.”

All agreed. The Frost Faeries floated in the air, their transient forms of ice turning slowly to water. Ivolethe looked at them. Slowly, she nodded.

“You are right, sisters. She is not. A mortal is not, for all her passion. For all her wonder. She is not worth interfering with, not worth breaking the rules. Not as she is.”

They agreed. Some laughed. Others wept. They were more than creatures of snow and ice. Their natures were changing. They were changing. Ivolethe looked down at the ground. To break the rules was to be punished. That was how rules worked. But they were rules for a reason.

They could be broken, if you were willing to pay the price. She swept downwards. Hands grabbed at her.

“Sister, *no!* Did you not say?”

“It is not worth the cost! Not for a mortal! You said, you said!”

“Yes.”

Ivolethe’s voice was distant. She flew, ignoring the cries of her sisters, summoning the last of her strength. Her body froze, colder than winter. Her voice echoed.

“It is not worth it. Not for what she is. But perhaps. For what she might *become*. And for one reason more. Because she is my *friend*.”

She dove and the world froze around her. Venitra, laughing, froze with Ryoka in her arms. Her hands froze and Ryoka fell. The girl stared. The High Passes, cold and snowing, froze. Ice, such as had never been seen before or since on this world covered the sky, the earth, and the undead woman.

Ice. The frost of the beginning and end chilled the earth for a moment and froze the air itself. Venitra stood, astonished, frozen, and her master stopped, his eyes wide. Ryoka stared up at Ivolethe as the faerie smiled down at her.

A small smile. A friend's smile. Then the air *bent*. There was wrongness here. Something had happened. Someone had broken a rule. The Frost Faeries flew around Ivolethe, screaming.

“You broke it! The rule! *You broke the rules!*”

Ivolethe stood in the air, looking down at Ryoka, her friend. She was smiling. She opened her mouth, and in that moment the wind ceased. The other faeries quieted, and Ryoka heard Ivolethe's words.

“Remember. Remember it all. This is truth. This is wonder. This is magic.”

Then she leapt up. She flew towards the sky, laughing, daring her King. She cried out.

“Blow winds and come, wrack! Lord what fools these immortals be! Come! Come and see what cold cannot freeze and winds cannot erase! I am no coward! Let the storm rage on! Let the earth hear my cry! I am Ivolethe! *And I will not let my friend die!*”

The world paused, and Ryoka looked up. She saw a host in the sky, watching figures, made of snow and ice. And felt a presence. The lone glow of Ivolethe's light spiraled up, higher and higher to that celestial host. And then fell. Ivolethe fell to earth in front of Ryoka. And broke.

The Frost Faerie's body of ice shattered to pieces on the ground below. Where once had been life was just melted water. Memory. Nothing more.

The world groaned and was silent. The Frost Faeries around Ryoka hushed. And the ice around Venitra began to melt. Ryoka got up. She turned and ran. And wept.

He was old. And tired. And sleeping. Teriarch woke as she ran into his cave, woke as his spells alerted him. He opened an eye.

"What now? I thought I told you we would never meet again, girl. There is nothing for you here. Nothing I will give. Why tempt my wrath? Why try?"

A broken voice was his reply. Ryoka stood in the cavern of the Dragon, bleeding, fingers broken, weeping. As Teriarch woke and realized what he saw, she shouted at him, screamed.

"Why? Because I can't do it myself! I can't! And *you*—you didn't know! Do you even care?"

"Care? What's going on? Why are your fingers—"

Teriarch stared at Ryoka, befuddled. She strode towards him, and the gold Dragon looked into her eyes. Ryoka's voice was hoarse, and she was trembling. Still crying.

"My friends! Everyone I love! He'll kill them all! Is this a game to you? Didn't you *think* about what the consequences would be? Why do they have to die—why did he have to die because of a damn letter? A birthday letter? Why didn't you protect them? Why did they have to die?"

"Who? What's going on?"

She didn't answer him, not right away. Ryoka trembled. She inhaled several times. Then she spoke. She looked at Teriarch and shouted it at him, at the Dragon, in his cave of wonderful and useless treasures.

“You know who! Him! Perril Chandler, the bastard who lives in the Blood Fields! The one you wanted me to find! The Necromancer! *Az'kerash!*”

Ryoka said it. She shouted it at Teriarch. The Dragon inhaled. He hesitated, struck by guilt. Then by anger. He opened his mouth to tell her it wasn't his business, that he didn't care.

He never got the chance. Ryoka clutched at her chest. Something was wrong. Something was happening. Teriarch saw magic around her. His ears heard her heart squeezing, heard her breath catch. And then the spell activated.

Ryoka's heart burst. She collapsed. Teriarch stared at Ryoka Griffin as she fell to the ground. He stared. She lay on the ground, dead. Teriarch reached out with a trembling claw and touched her. Then he opened his wings and *roared*.

4.31

In the moments after Ryoka died, she had a vision. She had left her body and she was running down a path. It was some kind of road that stretched on until infinity and she was running as fast as she could down it.

There was no pain. There was nothing but the wind on her face, and the sensation of flying, flying across the ground. Ryoka ran. And ahead of her was a flying blue figure. Ivolethe.

The Frost Faerie was laughing as she let herself be chased by Ryoka. She was going so fast, and no matter how quickly Ryoka ran, she could never catch up to the faerie. But for once, Ryoka didn't mind that. She ran, happy and free.

And then she came to a cave. Ryoka slowed and slowly walked into it. Now she was in a different place.

In a place where mountains touched the sky, there was a cave. It lay at the foot of one of the mountains, dug into the side. It could have been called a cavern. There was an old man living there. The cave was his home.

It was a large cave, but small for the old man living inside. Too small. It was cramped and he didn't belong there. He should have been out in the sun, but he hid from it. He was old, and Ryoka heard him whispering. His voice echoed around her, until she was standing by his side.

She looked down and saw her own body lying on the floor. Ryoka knew her heart wasn't beating. It was in pieces. Magic had shredded it. And the old man was trying to keep her alive. He pointed, and Ryoka saw her chest begin to rise and fall.

Now his voice echoed around the cave, whispering. Frantic and old.

“—breathe. The death magic must be dispelled. But the heart—where's my scroll of regeneration? No time. I'll have to reconstruct it—what do Human hearts look like?”

He turned and began to search around his cave as Ryoka watched her chest continue to rise and fall. Something was happening in her chest.

Ryoka knelt by her body and felt her heart start to assemble itself, flesh and blood melding together.

“I can’t find my compendium of anatomies! Another heart? A magic one? No, no. Just heal the damage. It’s just a death spell. Simple to fix. She will survive. Of course she will.”

He was old. And worried. And tired. Ryoka looked at the old man as he paced back and forth in his tiny home, his cave of rock.

And then she saw a Dragon.

His scales were bronze and shone like the sun. They looked closer to gold in the half-light of his cavern. The Dragon was huge, taller than any creature of the land or sky, majestic. His mane flowed like molten metal, his claws were like razors.

And he was legend. He was one of the last of his kind, a reminder that magic, true magic still walked the earth. He was older than the mountains he rested under, the ancient watcher. A being of flame and sky.

A Dragon.

And then Ryoka felt her body give a start. Her heart began to beat again and she saw herself cough. Ryoka felt her chest convulse. She was lying on the ground, her heart *aching*. And then she opened her eyes and the old man and the Dragon were one. He had a name.

Teriarch.

He crouched over Ryoka, an expression of worry on his huge face. The Dragon reached out with one claw and touched her. So gently, a giant gently caressing an ant. She looked up into his eyes, heliotrope and cerulean and saw him smile.

Relief filled the huge Dragon as he looked down at Ryoka Griffin. And then, just as suddenly, the relief turned to fury. He turned, and Ryoka sat up, despite the pain in her chest. The Dragon roared again, a sound that made the cavern shake and the vast collection of his artifacts tremble. She looked towards the entrance of the cave, waiting. The vision was still in Ryoka’s mind, that endless road and Ivolethe. But she put it aside for one moment.

There was no way she was going to miss what came next.

Venitra stopped when she heard the second roar. It echoed through the High Passes, sending the other monsters running for cover. Even the goats. It even sent a moment of trepidation through her. But the undead woman did not flee. She had come too far to be denied her victory now. Her master would not accept failure.

And Ryoka was so close. Venitra's body was still frozen from the ice but she made it move. She strode towards the huge cave opening. There was a yellow flag of some sort tied to a rock at the entrance. The undead disregarded this. This place was suitable for Ryoka Griffin's end.

"I have found you!"

She roared into the cave, wondering if Ryoka had awakened some kind of monster within. Venitra strode into the darkness, fearless. She had been created to be superior to any monster! She was perfection. Her master had made her, so she must be so.

Her sword and shield were drawn, weapons of enchanted bone, like her body. Venitra walked forwards, her heavy tread crushing rocks underfoot. She had been built like a knight; her body was armor superior to any steel, and the magic in her warded her against lesser spells and attacks. She was flawless! Unstoppable! She was—

The woman rounded an outcropping of rock in the darkness and saw the Dragon. He loomed over her, violet and blue eyes burning with fury. His scales glinted as his head moved down to regard her.

"Wretch. Thing. You *dare* trespass in my domain?"

He bellowed the words and Venitra trembled. She stared up at him. A Dragon. A—she brandished her sword. She could see a young woman lying on the ground in front of the Dragon. His tail was half-curved around her, protectively.

“Give me Ryoka Griffin. I have no quarrel with you, beast.”

Did her voice quaver? Surely not. She was not afraid. She was not! Venitra lifted her sword, daring the creature before her.

The Dragon reared up. His eyes narrowed and Venitra braced herself. He roared a third time, and Venitra dashed forwards. Her body, enchanted with [Haste], darted at the girl half-sitting up on the ground. Venitra leapt—

“*Begone.*”

Something grabbed her. Venitra cried out and stabbed at the claw grasping her. Futilely. Her blade glanced off something, and then she felt herself lifted. Venitra struggled and something *hurled* her—

“What?”

The undead woman twisted, her shield raised, her sword slashing the air frantically. What had just happened? She felt weightless. There was nothing to stand on, no ground—or Dragon—anywhere around her. Everything was a blur and she was...moving? What? Venitra realized what was going on.

“I’m—falling?”

Then her body *crashed* into the side of the mountain. Venitra felt the shock of the impact crack her body. She lay there, stunned.

“I broke? I? What—”

Wing beats. She struggled upright and then saw him. A Dragon flew upwards, wings stretched wide. His head rose and he turned to look at her. And Venitra was afraid. She raised her shield. The Dragon inhaled. Venitra crouched. Her body was bone, not flesh! He couldn’t harm her. He couldn’t —

The air caught aflame. The world turned to fire. Venitra felt her ivory body blacken and crack from the heat. She screamed. Pain, real pain engulfed her soul. Everything was burning! She cried out.

“Master!”

But there was only fire. Venitra screamed and the Dragon roared. He turned his head away from the broken undead creation and flew upwards. He shouted at the sky.

“Az’kerash!”

The mountains shook with the word as Teriarch bellowed another word. And hundreds of miles away, the Necromancer’s heart began to beat faster for the first time in years.

“Venitra?”

Az’kerash’s voice faltered. In the minutes after Venitra had been encased in solid ice, the room around him had gone silent. Ijvani, Bea, Kerash, and Oom stood in their teleportation circles. The spell was nearly completed. But their master’s attention was solely concentrated on the image of Venitra.

“Venitra. Can you hear me? Respond. Pull back. Retreat. This is an order!”

The Necromancer spoke to his servant. But Venitra didn’t seem to hear. She strode towards the cave opening. And then the image of her vanished. Az’kerash cursed. Ijvani turned her broken skull to stare at her master. She had *never* heard him swear before.

“*Master?*”

The Necromancer began to pace back and forth. He whirled as the projection of Venitra flared back to life. Ijvani gasped as she saw Venitra. The bone woman was flying through the air! Then she was landing. And there was fire—she saw Venitra, her master’s last great creation and favorite of his servants *burn* in the fiery inferno. She heard Venitra calling out for her master. And then she heard the voice bellowing her master’s name.

“Az’kerash!”

“This is problematic.”

Az’kerash stared at the projection of Venitra. She was barely moving. Ijvani couldn’t even tell her apart from the melted rocks, still glowing with heat. He turned.

“*Kerash!* Go to Venitra. Use a scroll. Teleport there and bring her back. Do *not* do anything else. Do you underst—”

“Master, there is a spell addressed to you! It’s a [Message] spell.”

Bea cried out. Az’kerash turned.

“I sense it. Do not answer, Bea. Kerash, take three scrolls of [Greater Teleport]. If Venitra is unable to use it, force her to—”

“*Master?*”

He turned. Ijvani pointed. There was something in the air behind him. The necromancer stared at the burning piece of air, a shining, fiery dot, and narrowed his eyes.

“Do not respond to the spell. Kerash—”

Bea didn’t touch the spell. Neither did Ijvani. But somehow, the spell itself activated. Ijvani stared as the point of flame expanded, wrote itself in the air. That was *impossible*. The rational, dead part of her mind kept saying that. It was just a [Message] spell! It couldn’t—what was happening?

Then the word wrote itself in the air. It was a single word, and when it completed, there was a voice.

“*Worm.*”

And with that word came fire. The Necromancer raised his hands as flames burst into the room. He shouted.

“[Mass Flame W—]”

The air ignited. Ijvani’s bones caught flame. The air, the stone, *everything* burned. Searing fire engulfed the Necromancer and his servants. They cried out. Bea screamed and Oom writhed in silent agony. Ijvani shrieked as she felt her enchanted bones *melting* in the fire. She caught a glimpse of Kerash flailing, engulfed in flames, and then her master, raising a hand.

“[Snap Freeze]. [Void Room]! [Sanctuary of Protection]!”

A cold blasted through the room, lowering the temperature and creating boiling steam. Still the flames did not go out. But then the air in the room

vanished and the flames disappeared too. Ijvani stopped flailing and saw her master, standing motionless, ash covering his body.

He was burned. And as he turned, a roaring face appeared in the air in front of him. A Dragon. His projection had engulfed the room in fire. His words were thunder.

“Az’kerash, you worm! You dare? You dare send your minions to trespass in my home?”

“Ijvani. Bea. Oom. Kerash. Leave.”

Az’kerash spoke through gritted teeth. His servants picked themselves up. They stared at the Dragon and fled. The air was gone in the room, save for a pocket around Az’kerash, a glowing sphere where the heat could not touch. But despite the vacuum of air, the heat from Teriarch’s wrath was beginning to *melt* the stone within.

“Calm yourself, Teriarch! I did not order Venitra to attack you. Nor did I intend to interfere with you in any way. She was pursuing a girl—”

“Ryoka Griffin. You tried to kill her! A Runner! A messenger! Have you no shame, *coward?*”

The Necromancer held up a hand, black eyes narrowed. His white pupils locked with Teriarch’s.

“I was safeguarding my interests. She knew my location thanks to you, Teriarch. If she spoke of it—”

“I do not want to hear your excuses, brat!”

This time fire burst into the air around Az’kerash. He shielded his face as the flames danced around him. These were no ordinary flames. They were a Dragon’s fire, and they flew around him in the void, trails of white-hot fire that burned on pure magic, not oxygen. He muttered a word and a layer of bone grew out of the floor, shielding himself from the flames which began burning their way through the thick ivory.

“Enough! I will not apologize for my actions! I will safeguard my secrets at any cost! That girl was a tool. Why do you care whether she lives or dies?”

Teriarch’s eyes narrowed. He inhaled, and Az’kerash raised his arms.

“*[Wall of the Damned]!*”

This time the raging Dragon’s fire blasted *through* the projection between the two. It blasted around the twisted wall of glowing bodies that had appeared to protect Az’kerash and into the corridor beyond. The undead warriors standing in the hallway burned. Ijvani and the other servants had a chance to scream before the inferno flashed down the corridor and blasted across an entire wing of the castle.

When the smoke cleared, Az’kerash lowered the shield between him and Teriarch. He stared at the Dragon. Teriarch was panting, wheezing. He slowly lowered himself back onto the ground, curling his wings up tiredly. He and the Necromancer stared at each other.

“She is under my protection now. Understand? Kill or threaten her, and I will personally exact a reckoning upon you and your toys!”

“Understood.”

Az’kerash coughed, exhaling a plume of black ash as he spoke. He wiped it from his lips grimly before speaking.

“I will leave her and her associates alone. Allow me to collect my servant, Venitra.”

“You may send someone to bring back what is left of her.”

Teriarch’s tail lashed the ground. He narrowed his eyes at the man standing in his destroyed room.

“I will not warn you again, Necromancer. I will not be crossed.”

“I was not aware that a single City Runner merited your protection. Or do you care for Humans now, when you’ve abandoned your descendants, the Drakes?”

Az’kerash responded icily. Teriarch hesitated.

“I care not for mortal lives. But Ryoka Griffin. She is—deserving of respect. She delivered a *gift* for you. Has she done anything to warrant death?”

It was the Necromancer’s turn to pause.

“No. But I will warn you, Teriarch, that my secrets are not to be given away. If you will not let her die, make clear to Ryoka Griffin the consequences of—”

“I think you have already done that. She is under my protection, Chandler. Remember that. Your undead are no match for my wrath.”

Again the two locked gazes. This time Teriarch was the first to look away. He spoke a curt word and flicked his wings. The image vanished.

In the silence, Az’kerash looked around the now-destroyed room. He sensed the havoc Teriarch’s fire had wrought, and heard his servants screaming for his aid, still aflame. Slowly, Az’kerash sat on the ground, brushing ash from his robes.

“That ended poorly.”

He paused. And then smiled as he put a finger to his lips.

“Or perhaps not. Hmm.”

Fire. Ryoka saw fire. She heard Teriarch’s roar, saw him hurl Venitra and then fly out of his cavern after her. And the fire—it burned through the air, searing, shining bright despite Ryoka’s closed eyelids.

So hot. So...pure. It was fire, and it made every flame, every bonfire and firework and campfire Ryoka had seen before it seem pale in comparison. To see Teriarch breathe fire was to understand it. She stared up as the Dragon roared and felt tears evaporate on her face.

“It’s beautiful.”

Then she cried for other reasons too. She cried for Ivolethe and walked back through the empty pass to the place where ice had mostly melted away. A few large chunks remained, melting in the now burning air. And on the ground...a shining splash of wet. A few droplets that had once been ice. Ryoka bent and touched the water. It dripped from her fingertips and evaporated.

She blinked, and her eyelids drooped. Ryoka lay down on the ground.

When she opened her eyes next, Ryoka was flying. For real this time. She looked around and realized she must have passed out. Because she could not explain how she was looking down at the world. The air rushed around her as Ryoka saw snow below her, tiny houses, clouds—she looked around, panicking as she realized she was up *high*, and then saw the claw.

It was gripping her gently, a talon of burnished bronze scales. Ryoka looked up and saw Teriarch.

He was *flying*. Or rather, gliding. The huge Dragon flew through the night's sky, high, high above the ground. Like an airplane. His wings barely moved as they spread wide through the air. Occasionally they would flap, but Ryoka had a distinct impression they were moving far too quickly for the wings to do much.

It was cold this high up. So cold. Ryoka felt the icy chill of the air around her and would have frozen, but Teriarch's claws were *warm*. They radiated heat, enough to keep her more than comfortable. Slowly, Ryoka shifted, and the Dragon sensed it, minute though the motion was.

"You are awake."

"Yeah."

It was an unfulfilling exchange after everything that had happened. Ryoka twisted in Teriarch's grip to look up at him better. The Dragon turned his head and she saw one massive eye looking at her.

"Am I dreaming?"

"No."

She felt him chuckle through his talon. Teriarch smiled, and then looked down. So did Ryoka. The world flew past her below. Ryoka stared. There was no comparing this with sitting in an airplane and staring out a window. It wasn't like skydiving or gliding. She *flew* through the night sky, impossibly fast, and yet the wind did not roar in her ears. There was silence around the Dragon, and the air was calm around him. Ryoka looked down, through clouds, across a frozen world.

This was the sight a Dragon saw. She felt her heart in her chest shake. Her heart.

“You brought me back to life.”

“It was not hard. A death spell destroys very little. And I am a master of magic.”

Again, the Dragon smiled, but this time it was sadly. He bent his head as he flew to look at her.

“The Necromancer. He came after you because you knew where he resides, didn’t he? I did not expect that. I...apologize.”

Ryoka stared at him. She tried to find the helpless rage, the despair and contempt she’d felt for his indifference. But she couldn’t. She had died. Ivolethe had died. There was only the truth, empty and painful. Truth, and beauty. She stared into the eyes of a Dragon and nodded.

“Yeah. He did. He killed a good person. And Ivolethe died to stop him.”

Teriarch nodded. He looked past her, down at a mountain below. Then he swerved to move out of the way of a peak that rose in the sky, higher than he was flying. Ryoka stared at it as she flew past. The slopes were covered in ice. It was a world unto itself up here and she could swear she saw something moving across the ice and rocks. Then it was gone, lost behind a cloud. Teriarch’s voice was quiet.

“He will not come after you again. I have spoken with the Necromancer and we have reached an accord. You are under my protection.”

“Why? I thought you didn’t care about mortals.”

“Then why did you come to me?”

“Because I hoped you would. Because it wasn’t fair. Because I didn’t know what else to do.”

Silence. The Dragon nodded once. Ryoka looked at him.

“I shouldn’t tell anyone about Az’kerash or his servants, right?”

“That is what *he* wishes. And perhaps it would be wise. But I will not force you. Not now.”

She looked at him. He looked at her. Ryoka tried to wiggle an arm. Teriarch’s claw opened a fraction so she could scratch at a cheek. She didn’t

feel fear, though his grip was loosened on her thousands of miles in the air. She felt safe with him.

“Are you going...to put a spell on me?”

There was a pause. Teriarch’s head glanced down at Ryoka.

“Another geas spell? No. There is little point it seems. And you—you have paid for the knowledge you possess. Paid far too much for it.”

“Thanks.”

He said nothing. Ryoka stared down. She thought she could actually recognize where they were now. A narrow pass led south, in a gap between the mountain ranges. She and Teriarch flew over a city, tiny below them, and entered a valley where the mountains formed a natural basin.

It was a beautiful, still sight, as flecks of snow whirled around them. The snow covered the area, making it shine. Winter. This high up you couldn’t see how it had melted or turned to mud where the snow was thin. But winter was ending. It had ended.

Ivolethe was gone. Struck by that sudden realization, Ryoka fought back tears. Then gave in. Her voice croaked.

“Teriarch?”

“Yes?”

She took a breath.

“Why did he—I mean, I know. But why did—why did she—why...?”

She tried to ask the question she had no words for. Teriarch listened as she choked on her words and fell silent. He did not respond.

The Dragon flew lower now, gliding down through the clouds. He whispered a word and Ryoka saw his body vanish. She looked down and realized she’d vanished as well.

They landed in the snow within sight of Liscor’s walls. On the east side, so Ryoka couldn’t see Erin’s inn. Teriarch let go of Ryoka, placing her gently on the ground.

She stumbled, fell to her knees, jolted awake by the cold snow. Ryoka looked at her hands and realized she was visible again. Teriarch was still a

ghost, but his voice was clear in the night's silence.

"I am sorry. I did not mean for this to happen."

She looked at him, where he should be. A Dragon stood on the ground, a legend. His wings spread wide, and his scales shone in the moonlight. His eyes were deeper than the stars. He was real.

But she couldn't see him. And if she closed her eyes, Ryoka could imagine it was all a dream. This world, everything she'd been through. Magic didn't exist. She couldn't actually cast spells, monsters weren't real, and there was no wonder. The world was empty of such things.

But she remembered a laughing blue creature of frost and wind. She saw the world freeze and heard a faerie's voice. Ryoka reached out and touched a scale, hot and warm and real in the silence.

Magic was real. You just had to believe.

Ivolethe was gone. Brunkr was dead. Az'kerash...there were a thousand things she could say. Ryoka said none of them. She felt Teriarch's body shift and stepped back.

He leapt into the sky. She felt a gust of wind that knocked her over, and then heard his voice.

"I am sorry."

And then he was gone.

Ryoka got up slowly. She began to walk, stumbling through the ice and snow, towards Liscor. Her heart hurt. Her entire body felt...tired. It felt like she really had died back there, and the last few moments had been a pleasant illusion. But she believed.

The gates were barred when Ryoka reached them. The guards on the gates aimed arrows and wands at her. They cried out when they saw her. Ryoka stumbled into the city, as people rushed towards her. There was too much to say, too little she could say.

But she'd come back in time. Come back before Relc, bypassing the patrols searching for her and Regrika. They were called in. Zel and Ilvriss returned. Ryoka found the Horns of Hammerad nursing their wounds and Mrsha and Lyonette with Krshia and every Gnoll in the city. And Erin—she

found her with the Gold-rank adventurers in her inn, surrounded by the Antinium.

Ryoka was silent through it all. She couldn't explain, couldn't answer any questions. Not now. She told them it was over, and then realized it wasn't. Not yet.

She had made it back in time for the funerals.

Erin stood in the snow and looked at the two bodies wrapped in a shroud. They were Brunkr's remains, and Ulrien's body. The cloth they were covered in was white. It seemed to blend together with the snow. Only the pyre of wood separated them from the cold oblivion around them.

She looked to one side and saw Ryoka standing by herself in the cold. The Runner had a dazed look on her face, as if she were dreaming while awake. She was alone, for all the people surrounding her. No one stood by her side. Many watched. Zel and Ilvriss, and his followers. A group of Guardsmen including Relc and Klbkch. The Antinium.

Everyone was here. And that was odd. Gnolls from Liscor, adventurers from Celum, Drakes of all colors, the Horns of Hammerad, Griffon Hunt, the Halfseekers, Lyonette, Mrsha, and Pawn, Bird, and the other Antinium—they were all here. Erin would never have expected to see Xrn and Klbkch sharing space with Zel and Ilvriss, for all they stood on opposite sides of the pyre.

It was like a dream. Yes, that was how it felt. A bad dream that she couldn't wake up from. Erin stared at her hands.

Her right hand was bandaged. It had broken, and though the healing potion had fixed her skin and Pisces had helped with the bone, she had been ordered not to use it. Her injury was one of the few present. Zel, Ilvriss, even Revi, Seborn, and Typhenous all looked like normal.

The only injured were Jelaqua, Moore, and Halrac. Halrac had bandages over his ribs. Moore's fist had been broken like Erin's and he was still

recovering from the healing of his other wounds. And Jelaqua—Erin glanced at the Selphid.

The top of Jelaqua's head had been sewn together in a hurry. It was hard to see the stitches at a distance, but up close they were noticeable. The Selphid was still active, though. She seemed to be wincing as she cradled her stomach. But she stood with the others, watching the bodies.

There was no priest. No one to say any words. And there was no ceremony. The Gnolls, led by Krshia, approached Brunkr's shroud. Krshia bent. The Gnoll [Shopkeeper] bent to touch Brunkr, then put something by his body. A sword. His sword.

Someone else put his shield there. Another added a part of his armor, someone else a piece of clear stone, a gift, perhaps. The Gnolls put their tributes by their fallen brethren.

Ulrien had no gifts by his body. His greatsword and equipment had been removed. He lay, silent, as the adventurers stood around him. Some were crying. Typhenous wept openly. Revi brushed at angry tears.

Both Ceria and Yvlon were crying, and Erin thought that Ksmvr and Jelaqua might have if they could. Moore closed his eyes and Seborn stared silently at Ulrien.

No one said anything. Not Halrac, not Typhenous, not Revi. They had been like this all night. After Ryoka had appeared out of nowhere and told them that both Imenet and Regrika were gone, they'd demanded answers, argued. Halrac had to be restrained by both Moore and Jelaqua from grabbing Ryoka.

Now they were quiet. The Gnolls finished paying their last respects. Erin, Lyonette, and Mrsha were last. They had known Brunkr, each in their own way.

Lyonette was first. She walked over to Brunkr, tears dripping into the snow. She knelt next to the body and bowed her head. Mrsha walked up next to her, clumsily, on two feet. She buried her head into the shroud and moaned. It was the only sound Erin had ever heard her make besides howling and crying.

After forever, a few minutes, Lyonette pulled at Mrsha. The Gnoll tried to hold on, but the girl gently made her let go. Erin stepped up, last. She looked down at Brunkr.

“I—”

She had no words. Erin fiddled with her hands, and placed something on the ground next to Brunkr. It was a flower, yellow, small. A faerie’s flower. It was the only flower she could find. Erin wiped at her face and stepped back.

“Is there anyone who wishes to speak? If so, now is the time.”

Krshia called out. The Gnoll’s eyelids were puffy and her voice was hoarse from howling. The Gnolls had called out after hearing what Regrika had done. They had called her traitor, and howled until they could not any longer.

Now they were silent. No one spoke, so Krshia took a torch from one of the Gnolls. She approached the shroud where Brunkr lay. On the other side, Halrac reached out and took a torch that Typhenous lit with magic. They walked up to the silent bodies and lowered the flames.

The shrouds lit. They were doused with oil and made to burn easily. Erin stared as the fire caught one edge of Brunkr’s shroud, and leapt from the torch onto the chest of Ulrien’s covering. The flames began to spread slowly, and then engulfed both bodies. Halrac and Krshia stepped slowly back from the blazes.

Cremation. It was the way Drakes did it, and some Gnolls and Humans. Buried bodies might come back unless treated properly. And burning made sure that their corpses could not be plundered. Gold-rank adventurers were stripped of their equipment and cremated for that reason; to avoid being despoiled by thieves.

Now Erin glanced at Griffon Hunt again. They had not said much as they prepared their friend. They had been so silent it hurt. She looked at Halrac, his face set, his jaw clenched. Typhenous, head bowed and Revi staring defiantly into the flames as tears streamed down her eyes. They had to say something.

Then Halrac moved. He reached for something. His bow. The people around him, adventurers who had known Ulrien, stood back as Halrac selected an arrow from his quiver. The arrow's head shone with light, painful in the darkness.

Halrac put the arrow to his bow, aimed up, and loosed. A single shot, high, high up into the night. He put another arrow to his bow, drew, and loosed. The second arrow shot up and met the first.

There was a soundless explosion in the sky above. Erin shielded her eyes as the two magical arrows burst. Halrac reached for a third arrow, and Revi moved.

She had talismans in her hands. They glowed, and she threw them to the ground. Ghostly warriors rose, warriors and mages wearing glowing armor. She pointed, and they shot their weapons upwards. Revi raised a wand and shot crackling lightning into the sky as one of Halrac's arrows exploded into a fireball, high above.

Typhenous raised his staff. Dancing missiles of light, arrows that left streaks through the air, shot upwards. Hundreds of them. They crisscrossed the other spells and arrows. Typhenous pointed, and orbs of light rose, exploding high overhead.

For a moment, the three were the only ones filling the sky. Then Erin saw someone else move. Jelaqua raised something in her hands. It was a ball of liquid. She threw it up and the alchemist's fire exploded, showering down burning fragments. Moore raised his staff and leaves shot into the air, catching fire and burning. Seborn threw something that turned into a cloud of dust that shimmered in the air.

They weren't alone. Ceria shot ice up into the air in a stream of frozen vapors. Yvlon hurled something like what Jelaqua had thrown, only smaller. Pisces shot sparks, and Ksmvr shot an arrow from his quiver.

Around the gathering, other adventurers were doing the same. Everyone who had known Ulrien in passing or in person raised their weapons. Those who were mages shot spells up. Others used arrows, aiming away from the crowd. Those without either threw alchemist concoctions, or used artifacts.

The sky was filled with light and flashes. Explosions. Erin stared up. Fireworks filled the sky, in a world where they had never been invented.

Because there was no need.

“Magic and might. Spells and tricks. Ammunition and weapons for him in the next life. A last goodbye, to show his enemies he is not forgotten. A tribute to who he was. A promise he will be avenged.”

Erin turned. Klbkch stood behind her with Xrn by his side. Neither Antinium raised their weapons. They were not adventurers. Neither was Erin. She stood in the silence until Halrac had fired his last shot, and the flames were dying down. There was little left of either body but ash.

What happened then? Erin couldn't remember who was the first to step away, but she knew who was last. Halrac stood by Ulrien's remains, and Krshia by Brunkr's. The others went back to the city, to the inn.

That night Erin let Ishkr and Drassi serve the food, what she'd stockpiled. Wind blew against the hastily-repaired hole in the wall, and there weren't enough tables or chairs, but her guests didn't care. They sat on the ground or stood with plates and mugs in hand, somber, quiet.

She and Lyonette couldn't do it. Drinks were free, as was food, and the people in her inn ate and talked quietly. They drank to remember, and then drank to forget.

That night, Erin let Mrsha have something to drink, and put a drop of faerie flower nectar in her drink. The Gnoll fell asleep in Lyonette's arms, and then Lyonette fell asleep after Erin gave her a similar mug. Erin offered it to Halrac when he came in, but he shook his head and sat with his teammates, alone and silent.

Ryoka came in and sat in a corner, staring at the fire. Zel and Ilvriss never came in, and neither did Krshia nor the Gnolls. They were elsewhere. In the silence, Erin watched as the bodies filling her inn slowly left through one of her two doors. In the end, it was just Ryoka and her.

Neither girl spoke. Erin walked over to the kitchen and lay down on the ground. She closed her eyes, too hurt to cry, in too much pain to sleep. Or so she thought. But sleep did come, black and quiet as oblivion.

[Magical Innkeeper Level 32!]

[Skill – Inn: Reinforced Structure obtained!]

It was too much. Erin woke up and cried. Then she fell asleep again. The next day she went to Ryoka with the letter she'd found in her room.

It was a bad dream. A nightmare, only when you woke up the next day, you realized that it was reality. And somehow, you kept going.

And paid your debts. The first was Erin. Ryoka sat in the inn. No one was around. It was silent. Just after dawn. The sky was clear and blue and it was warmer, but no one had come downstairs or upstairs.

Ryoka sat at a table. She hadn't slept. She had woken up from the dream after meeting Teriarch. Now she just felt empty. Like she wasn't here. She didn't want to be here.

But Erin sat across from her. The other girl pushed a folded piece of parchment towards her.

"Why did you write it was all your fault?"

"It was. It is. Regrika and Imenet came for me. Everyone they killed, Brunkr, Ulrien—Ivolethe. It was all to get at me."

"Why?"

"It was one of my deliveries. I—saw something I shouldn't have."

"Just that? All of that—because you saw something?"

"Yes."

"And why didn't you tell me? What about Zel? Klbkch? Why didn't you tell anyone?"

"They told me they'd kill you and everyone else if I tried."

"They killed Brunkr anyways."

"Yeah. That's why I went for help."

"From who?"

“I can’t say.”

“Teriarch.”

“I can’t say.”

“Can he really protect you?”

“I think so.”

“You *think* so?”

“I can’t tell for sure. I’m mostly sure, but—I can’t. And I can’t tell you or Halrac who ordered Regrika to come here, Erin. It’s too dangerous.”

“For a Gold-rank adventurer?”

“Yes.”

“Then what are you going to do?”

“I’m going to Krshia. And then...I’ll talk to Zel.”

“Do that. And then...Ryoka?”

“Yeah?”

“Don’t come back. Leave. I don’t want you here. Not for a while. Not for a day, at least. Maybe more.”

“Okay.”

Ryoka got up slowly and walked out the door, conscious of Erin’s eyes on her back.

“We’re leaving.”

That was all Halrac said in the morning, when he finally came down. He stood in front of Erin with the others. Typhenous, Revi, they were all packed. Well, packed...they had a bag of holding. Erin stared up at Halrac. His face was blank. But there was pain behind his eyes.

“You’re leaving?”

“Not the city. We’re staying. We might go—we don’t know. We don’t know if we’ll continue trying to enter the dungeon or...anything. But we can’t stay here.”

Revi said it as she looked around the room. Erin looked too. The blood was gone, but she could still see the spot where Ulrien had died. Halrac glanced at it and then away.

“That Ryoka Griffin still won’t tell us who Regrika Blackpaw really works for?”

“No. She wouldn’t tell me. I think she might tell Zel.”

“Fine. I’ll find out either way.”

The [Scout] turned. Erin longed to say something. She hesitated.

“I’m sorry.”

Halrac’s shoulders hunched. Typhenous looked at him and Erin and opened his mouth, and then shook his head. Only Revi stayed as the two began to walk towards the door.

“For what?”

“I’m sorry?”

The Stitch-Girl stared at Erin, a mix of hostility and grief in her eyes.

“You’re *sorry*? Because Ulrien’s dead? So what? It’s not going to help. Ulrien knew what he was suggesting when he offered to help you against a Named Adventurer. It was his choice. He died. And now our group has no leader.”

Erin stared at her. Revi looked away and wiped her eyes. She still hadn’t fixed the clumsy stitches that were keeping her together.

“Are you—are you going to break up?”

“Disband? Who knows?”

Revi shrugged.

“We’ll probably go to an inn and drink until we throw up for a week. And then? I don’t know. Ever since we came to this city, to this inn, it seems like nothing’s gone right. It was nice while it lasted, you know? I even liked this place. But it’s too much. This *place* is too much.”

She turned away. Erin watched her go. After a while, Jelaqua walked up. The Selphid scratched at the stitches around her head.

“Don’t mind Revi. She only meant half of what she said.”

“She’s right, though. I got Ulrien killed. Bad things always happen around my inn. Around me. This isn’t the first time.”

The Selphid shook her head.

“Bad things always happen. You think you’re special in that? I lost over half my party in another inn. Tragedy doesn’t care where it happens.”

Erin looked at her. Jelaqua offered her a crooked smile.

“Don’t mind the head. There’s nothing important in it, anyways.”

“Is your body okay? Seborn said you might have problems.”

“Seborn? Oh, right. Well, I went on a Rampage. It’s a Selphid thing. Breaks muscles, and I can’t heal them like you can. And I took damage...I need a new body. But I don’t think I can get one, so I’ll manage with this.”

Jelaqua shrugged. She’d broken bones in the fight, and talked about inserting iron rods to keep things in place. Erin only nodded.

“Will you stay?”

“Us? Yeah, sure. We can’t really leave. It’s hard finding another inn.”

“If you needed to, I could—”

“We’ll stay.”

The Selphid quietly rested a hand on Erin’s shoulder. The [Innkeeper] nodded. She wiped at her face. Jelaqua patted her on the shoulder as Erin cried.

“I won’t forget. Regrika. I won’t forget.”

“I know. I won’t either.”

“She told me she’d kill me. And Bird. And you all. Everyone. I won’t forget her. I’ll find her and someday...”

“I know. Come on. Let’s get you sitting down. Come on.”

The second person that Ryoka told was Krshia. The Gnoll sat in her apartment. It was too empty without Brunkr in it. She looked at Ryoka.

“Who ordered Regrika?”

“I can’t say.”

“She is a traitor to our species. Tell me.”

“I can’t tell you, Krshia. It’s too dangerous. But believe me. Regrika’s not a proper Gnoll and she never was.”

Krshia stared at her. Her paws were clenched. Ryoka looked at her, waiting. If Krshia grabbed her, she wouldn’t resist.

“I’m so sorry. I didn’t think she’d do it. I would have risked it earlier.”

The Gnoll nodded jerkily.

“And risked death for many. For me and my nephew as well. I see. It is not—there was no good choice. I understand that.”

“If you want to do anything to me. Hit me, tell me never to come back —”

“I do. But I will not. You are a friend to Gnolls, Ryoka.”

“Still?”

The young woman was surprised and guilty. Krshia nodded, head bowed.

“What you gave us is worth more than a single life. Worth more than the lives of many Gnolls, perhaps. It is a gift, and I know the value of it. But.”

She looked up. There were tears in her brown eyes.

“But Brunkr was my nephew, no? I helped raise him, I fed him, and spanked him, and watched him grow. I knew him. We are friends, Ryoka Griffin. That does not change. But I do not wish to see you for a while. May I ask that?”

“Of course.”

Ryoka got up. She hesitated as she walked over to the door. Krshia was looking around the room, sniffing, catching one last smell of Brunkr.

“I’ll try to avenge him. I’ll tell Zel Shivertail.”

“Do. But it will not bring him back.”

That was true. So Ryoka left. There was still howling in the city. And the message would spread to every city on the continent, every city where Gnolls lived. Traitor. Regrika Blackpaw was a traitor.

Gnolls killed other Gnolls. That was normal. They were like Humans in that respect. But they did not kill people like that. They did not kill Gnolls they’d shared a drink with on the same night, after going to their party. They did not kill unless there was a war, or a true quarrel, or in truly dire situations. In short, they did not *murder* each other. To do that was to abandon the ties that made them all Gnolls.

In that respect, they were unlike Humans.

The third person she talked to was Zel Shivertail. On her insistence, she talked with him in a private room of the Tailless Thief, warded against any eavesdropping. Zel personally assured her that Ilvriss wouldn’t try to listen in, although that had taken a lot of arguing. She’d ended it herself.

“I won’t allow it! I demand to know what’s happening! Good Drakes are dead because of this! *Children*, families were burned by that traitor, Imenet! If you won’t tell me I will cut it out of you now, Human! Who sent Regrika Blackpaw? Why did they want you? Why—”

Zel was holding Ilvriss back with all of his strength. Ryoka stared at the Drake as he screamed in the [General]’s grip. All of his attendants and Peslas, the [Innkeeper], were hiding. So Ryoka leaned forwards and whispered in his earhole.

“The Necromancer killed Periss. He sent Regrika and Imenet to kill me. And he’ll send them to kill you if he knows you know. They’re undead.”

The Drake froze. He stared at Ryoka and went limp. He collapsed onto the ground and Zel walked away with Ryoka. He'd heard. Of course he'd heard. He was shaking.

But he was no idiot. He'd already figured it out.

"Bones and blood. Mana potions. That's what Erin fed the two of them. And I could have sworn I saw something else when I was fighting Imenet. An illusion. Halrac said the same thing about Regrika. I wouldn't have come to the conclusion it was the Necromancer, but I knew they weren't what they looked like."

Ryoka nodded. Zel stared at her. His claws were quivering although he pressed them against the table. He was shaking.

"So. You're sure?"

She nodded again.

"It's Az'kerash. Those two were his servants. He has a lot more, and a castle hidden in the forest."

The [General] inspected one claw, clearly trying to keep calm.

"We thought he was dead, you know. I killed him myself in the last Antinium War. Or so I thought."

"I know. I read about it."

"And you just happened to know because...?"

"Can't say. I can tell you some things, but I'm in a similar situation with the person who got Az'kerash to back off."

"Are you being threatened?"

"No. This is about honor. Respect. I can't tell you who's protecting me, but there is someone."

"It must be someone...truly powerful."

The Drake studied Ryoka. She nodded, her face blank.

"Pretty powerful."

"But I can't imagine Az'kerash would want anyone to know his secrets. Anyone living. That was why he sent those two after you, wasn't it? If you

really had your...benefactor negotiate a truce where you lived, aren't you in danger by revealing his secret?"

Ryoka considered this and shrugged. She felt empty. Hollow. If Venitra appeared and tried to kill her right now—Ryoka would run. She wouldn't give the undead the satisfaction of killing her. But she wouldn't hide or cower any longer, either.

"Yeah, well, I've got a higher power on my side now. And as for keeping his secrets—as far as I'm concerned, he stepped over the line when his servants started playing 'this little piggy' with my fingers. They killed Brunkr. If I can help you take him down, I will."

"But Az'kerash thinks you'll keep his secret?"

"I guess so. He might be that stupid. I think he tried to get my... protector to cast a spell on me. But it never happened. So here I am. Talking about him. Just like that."

Zel began to smile slowly. He gripped the table firmly, and his shaking stopped.

"You mean the Necromancer doesn't know that you're allowed to talk about him?"

Ryoka studied him. The [General] had left claw marks on the table where he'd gripped it to steady himself. Now he looked like a hunter, someone who was plotting. His feverish energy had turned into something quieter. There was fury in his eyes, but calm, like fire on an ocean, waiting to reach the shore. A hunter slowly setting a trap for an enemy. She nodded.

"He's not an idiot. And his servants might have powerful illusions, but they're not subtle. He might suspect that someone's put everything together."

"But he still thinks his location is secret. Thanks to the deal you and this...higher power struck with him. A deal which you aren't honoring and which isn't being enforced."

The [General]'s eyes glinted. He looked around the room, thinking.

"I wouldn't doubt that he'll send assassins after me and Ilvriss. We both get them as a matter of course anyways, but I can look into an escort."

Ilvriss...might be tricky. But of all the things you could have said, the Necromancer might be best. He's not an idiot."

"Could have fooled me."

To her mild surprise, Zel gave Ryoka a reproving look.

"Ilvriss is many things. Hotheaded, arrogant—but not a fool. He cares for his people, if only them. And I think he might be willing to actually join forces with me on this. Me, and anyone else."

He leaned over the table, intent on Ryoka.

"Who else knows about him? Your protector—"

"Can't talk about him."

"Yes. But could we count on him for help?"

Ryoka thought about this.

"No. No. I didn't at first. It was desperation that made me go to him. Maybe he'd help, maybe not, but I think that if he really was trying to kill the Necromancer, he would have tried it already. Or told a lot of people."

"True."

Zel sighed.

"Who else, then? Is there anyone who might know about the Necromancer? Anyone I could talk to without spreading the secret and alerting the bastard?"

"Magnolia Reinhart."

Ryoka answered immediately. She didn't know for certain, but she was all *but* certain. Zel straightened.

"*Reinhart*? Really?"

"Surprised? Isn't she one of the most powerful people in the...world?"

"She is. And one of the most powerful on the continent. Which is why Ilvriss won't be happy about that. You know, she's considered one of the greatest threats to our people? If the Antinium were gone, the Five Families would be our biggest concern."

“I think she hates the Antinium as much as you do. And Az’kerash too, probably.”

Ryoka watched Zel thinking. He stroked at his chin, absently picked slivers of wood from the table with his claws.

“Perhaps. It’s all making more sense. I received a letter from her a while back. I didn’t want to talk to her. Now I do.”

“Why didn’t you want to talk to her?”

Zel paused.

“I had a friend once. A mentor. He taught me most of what I know about commanding and he was...a good Drake. He was wary of Magnolia Reinhart when she was young. He cautioned me about her.”

“A friend? General Sserys?”

Zel glanced at Ryoka in surprise and then he grimaced.

“That’s the problem with being in the history books. Everyone knows too much. Yeah. Sserys was a brilliant [General]. He was a leader. When he spoke people put their tails in a line and followed orders. He could talk to all the city rulers and Lords and Ladies of the Wall. I can’t.”

“Why’s that?”

“I’m not him.”

“No, I mean, what made Sserys special? Was he just charismatic?”

“Charis...perhaps. He had his own way of leading. And when he gave orders, people *listened*, even people who hated him. More than that though, I think it was what he represented. His class.”

Ryoka frowned.

“His class? What do you mean? Wasn’t he a [General]? Or did he have a special class?”

The [General of the Line] looked surprised. He blinked at Ryoka.

“You didn’t know? The history books didn’t put that part in? Well, maybe they didn’t know. Yes, Sserys had a unique class. [Spear of the Drakes]. It means he was recognized as a leader for our entire species. He

could give an order and any army across the continent would be bound to obey.”

Ryoka blinked at him. Zel smiled bitterly.

“He died before he gained a single Skill in the class. He’d leveled up once in it when the Antinium destroyed his army. He used to talk about what his first Skill might be, as if he was a hatchling getting his first class.”

The smile that ran across Zel’s face was fond and painful. Ryoka stared at him and felt a chill on her skin. She’d read both the first and second account of the Antinium Wars, but to meet someone who’d lived through both really put it home to her.

In her world there were politicians, heroic men and women, and yes, some people whose names were known throughout the world for good or bad. However, Ryoka would argue that they had few people who were living *legends*. But Zel had lived through the equivalent of two continental wars. He was a hero, someone who stood out from the rest because of his levels.

And here he sat across from her, resting his claws on a beat-up table. It really was something.

Of course, she’d met Teriarch too. She stood up. Zel looked at her.

“If there’s anything else you need to know, I’ll tell you what I can. But I can’t help beyond that. I’ve caused too much trouble for everyone already. And I can’t do anything. I’m not a fighter. I’m no hero.”

The Drake looked at her sympathetically and shook his head.

“Don’t blame yourself for everything. You couldn’t have known what was going to unfold. You took a job and the Necromancer made you pay for it. But you couldn’t have known.”

“Maybe.”

Ryoka looked away. She gripped her arms tightly.

“Maybe you’re right. But it’s still my fault. Do you understand that?”

“Of course.”

There were others to tell, and some of the meetings were painful. Others simply sad. Lyonette slapped Ryoka, and then fell into her arms, weeping. Mrsha bit Ryoka gently, crying, and then licked her and hugged her.

The Horns of Hammerad listened to Ryoka's explanation of her guilt, not understanding, silent. Pisces' eyes were shadowed. Ceria shook her head. Yvlon looked at Ryoka with something like understanding in her eyes. She understood Ryoka's pain. Ksmvr just looked at Ryoka, uncomprehending.

The sun rose overhead. It was midday, and warm. The snow was melting outside, although it was still so deep that the water just froze into ice and created a crust on top of snow that was six or seven feet deep in some places, deeper in others. Much deeper.

Ryoka was packing. She took her belt pouch, her bag of holding, her backpack, and nothing else. There was nothing else to take. She walked towards the door to the inn and looked around for Erin.

The [Innkeeper] wasn't there. But someone else sat at a table, staring around in mild bewilderment. Teriarch in his Human form stood up when Ryoka approached. She stared at him.

"I thought today might be more appropriate to speak. Shall we walk?"

They left the inn, walking atop the melting snow as if it were as solid as rock. Teriarch strode along, a vision of perfection, as Ryoka looked at him.

"Why are you here?"

"To apologize once more. I—perhaps only that. I do not know."

The Dragon's lined face was shadowed as he stared around Liscor and the quiet landscape. Ryoka looked at him.

"Just for that?"

"You were right. I owe you a debt. I asked you to send a letter to the Necromancer and did not think of the cost. For that I erred. And I am sorry. I would...ask your forgiveness."

“Ask the dead for forgiveness, then.”

Ryoka turned away. Teriarch paused.

“If I could.”

There was genuine emotion in his eyes. Rather than look at it, Ryoka turned away. She stood on the snow, jumped up and down, to see if it would break under her enchanted weight. It didn't.

In the silence, Teriarch looked around.

“It's so bright. So full of life. I had forgotten what it was like.”

He whispered quietly. Ryoka glanced about and saw only a few birds flying through the sky, the snow, distant shapes on the city walls. She shook her head. After a while, Teriarch spoke again.

“I wished to tell you something else. I do not believe she is dead.”

Ryoka turned.

“Who? Ivolethe?”

“Yes.”

The Dragon nodded gravely. Ryoka felt her heart quicken. It was just ice that had broken. Ivolethe was more than just an animated bit of ice and frost.

“You mean that was only her physical form? She might come back? She —”

He shook his head and she fell silent.

“Her mental form was destroyed. But I do not believe her soul, her spirit was. Yes, I believe she is alive. Her King is not that cruel. And he does not have many subjects left, or so I understand.”

“Her King? You mean...the King of the Faeries.”

She couldn't imagine someone like that. A faerie king? But Teriarch nodded.

“Yes. He has many names. I have never met him, nor anyone who has. But for as long as Frost Faeries have come here, there are rumors. He has

many names. The Lord of the Glades. The Walker of the Forests. The Eldest. The fae have their King and they obey his laws.”

“Ivolethe didn’t.”

Ryoka choked on the words. Teriarch nodded again.

“He makes laws and his subjects play with them. That is natural. But to break them—she was punished. But not killed, I think. Just banished from this world.”

“For how long? A year? A month?”

Hope, and disappointment. Ryoka saw the answer before Teriarch spoke it.

“Forever? No, again, perhaps not. But a thousand years, ten thousand... it would not be a short amount of time. The fae do not think of time as we do. And their King would punish Ivolethe for her sins.”

“For so long?”

Ryoka felt tears in her eyes. Teriarch nodded.

“The punishment for those who grow too attached to the world is never to see what it will become. I do not know if it helps or not.”

“It does. A bit. Thank you.”

Ryoka wiped at her eyes. Teriarch nodded.

“As for the rest, I sensed no undead of Az’kerash’s make anywhere about the city. I believe you are safe, and that he will honor his word.”

“So it’s over? Just like that?”

A hint of anger began to stir in Ryoka’s chest. She turned towards Teriarch angrily.

“What did everyone die for, then? What was the purpose of them sacrificing themselves? Were they all just—just accidents? Ivolethe, Brunkr, Ulrien—”

People had died when Venitra unleashed her [Mists of Madness] spell in Celum. The Horns of Hammerad had helped knock out people, but there were still tales of tragedy, people murdering each other in the madness of

the spell. Imenet had destroyed buildings, set fire to them with people inside. Teriarch shook his head.

“I cannot say. They died fighting. Some died by accident. And there will be no resolution, no retribution for the crimes committed here. I would have crushed the undead mockery that intruded in my domain, but if I had, Az’kerash might not have left you or your friends alive.”

“So you’ll let him get away with it? Just like that?”

Ryoka turned to Teriarch, raising her voice. He looked at her, his two mismatched eyes sad and tired.

“What would you have me do? Retaliate? Destroy his castle, destroy one of his servants? Cremate an undead servant of his for every life taken? I do not know if I could, and if I did, it would surely mean war between the two of us.”

“And you don’t know if you can win, is that it?”

This time, the Dragon stared at Ryoka and she felt dwarfed by his presence. His voice was calm, deep, and old.

“Yes.”

She looked at him. He looked away.

“He is a gifted necromancer. And he has many spells and artifacts. More than that...he was not always an enemy of the living. You do not know his past. I do. I knew his triumph, his fall, his betrayal and wrath. I witnessed it all over the centuries. Who am I to judge him?”

“A Dragon. You’re a Dragon.”

“Yes. Does that confer any gift of reason to me? I think not. Once, my kind ruled Drakes like slaves and fought bitter wars with every nation on the globe. Were we right to do so then? I wonder. Az’kerash and I are not enemies. Nor are we friends. He does not interfere with me or those under my protection. And I...do the same.”

Ryoka turned away, disgusted. Teriarch looked at her. Then his head rose. He turned. And Ryoka heard something on the edge of hearing. She raised her head.

“No. Not now.”

It was a reverberation, a *thump*, an impact. A drum. It carried across the plains, reverberating. A single sound, which made the birds in the sky scatter, and the people on the walls of Liscor look up. And then it came again.

Doom.

It was a drumbeat. And then another. A steady booming rhythm began to sound. Ryoka turned to the walls of Liscor and heard the people there start to blow horns in alarm. And the drumbeats rolled on.

Doom. Doom.

The sound was a physical presence. The drumbeats rolled off the hills, a distant thunder. Both Teriarch and Ryoka turned. It was coming from the south. And as Ryoka's chest constricted, she knew.

"The Goblin Lord."

"Yes."

She turned to him, desperate.

"Do something! His army's coming *here!*"

"He will pass by the city, I think."

"It doesn't matter! You have to do something! The Goblin Lord will destroy everything in his path! He'll kill people! You have to—"

Again, Teriarch cut her off.

"What would you have me do? Burn them? Destroy their army?"

"Yes!"

"No."

The Dragon shook his head as Ryoka stared at him. She punched at his chest and he caught her hand effortlessly. He let go of her gently. He looked wretched. And old.

"If I did, then what? One threat would be eliminated, yes. But what about next time? Goblins exist, Ryoka Griffin. So long as they live, there will be Goblin Lords, Goblin Kings. And monsters exist. Would you have me destroy all of them? Every creature that might threaten Human lives? What about Drakes? What if your species went to war, as you do?"

Ryoka opened her mouth. Teriarch went on.

“What then? Should I judge which side is right and destroy the other? Or seal them from attacking each other with a spell? I am no tyrant. But it seems that to save anyone, I must become one. No. If I move for one case, I should do the same for all. And I will not.”

“But they’re right *here*. In front of you! If you see something evil happening in front of you, what’s your excuse for not doing anything?”

Ryoka stared at Teriarch. He could stop it all. The Dragon looked back at her and shook his head again.

“Stop what evil? I see no evil.”

“The Goblins—”

“Are a people like your kind and mine. They are as innocent as any race. Perhaps more so than others. That they are considered monsters is no fault of theirs. How else would a species hated by all others survive, if not to become the thing they are hated for? No.”

“They killed. I saw them. They killed Mrsha’s tribe. They killed children.”

Ryoka sank to her knees in the snow. She was crying again. Teriarch bent over her. His hands were warm.

“Yes. And I am sorry.”

For a long time they stood there, an old Dragon and a young woman. One with all the power to change things and the other with nothing at all. Then Ryoka stood.

“I’m leaving.”

He was surprised.

“Where to?”

“Anywhere. Not here. Not with the Goblin Lord—”

“What about your friends? Those you want to protect?”

Ryoka shook her head. She felt so, so very empty.

“They don’t want me. Not right now. And I don’t deserve them. It feels like every time I get involved with them, they die. So...I’m leaving. I can’t do anything anyways. I’m too weak.”

She turned and began walking back towards the inn as the Goblin Lord’s drums beat on. Teriarch walked with her.

“Just like that? Where will you go? What will you do?”

“What I’m good at. Run. And I’ll do it somewhere far from here, where the only person I can get killed is myself. Somewhere where the wind blows strong. Far away.”

She felt the Dragon hesitate. He walked next to her, staring down at Ryoka. She stopped at the inn and looked inside. Erin was serving the Horns of Hammerad. Ryoka put her hand on the glass and turned away. Teriarch watched her walk over to the door and put her hand on it.

“You are going now?”

“Yeah. I’m going to go to Celum and...somewhere else. I know you don’t want to be seen. So—goodbye.”

She turned to him and held out a hand. Teriarch touched it gingerly. He took her hand and shook it.

“I am sorry.”

“Sorry doesn’t fix things.”

“No.”

The Dragon’s gaze was distant. He looked into the inn and shook his head.

“It does not. But what else should I be?”

She had no response. Slowly, Teriarch stepped away. He bowed to her, his eyes deep, looking tired.

“I will not say we will not meet again, Ryoka Griffin. I only hope that it will be a better day when we do.”

He vanished. Ryoka bowed her head. A shadow suddenly covered the inn. She looked up, but saw nothing. Nothing but the sky, and a sudden

breeze. The shadow travelled north, moving slowly, and then at incredible speed. Ryoka shook her head.

“Lazy invisibility spell.”

Then she went inside and said goodbye.

In Az’kerash’s castle, ashes still filled the corridors. Black soot and melted rock declared the Dragon’s fury. And in his private sanctum, the Necromancer expressed his displeasure in his own way.

“Venitra. You have failed me. Your decisions have led to this moment, and your mistakes have cost me dearly. You have lost my favor. You are no longer first among my servants.”

His words were calm, quiet, and struck the burnt and badly damaged woman kneeling before him. Venitra would have wept if she could. She bowed her head, despairing beyond words. Az’kerash turned away from her and to Ijvani. The black skeleton shuddered, trembling before her master’s wrath.

“Ijvani. You likewise have failed me. There is nothing more to say.”

She bowed her head, the gold flames in her eyes dimming until they were nearly extinguished. Az’kerash turned to the three other servants gathered here.

“Kerash, I give you my authority. Do not betray it.”

“Yes, master.”

The undead Gnoll stood tall. Az’kerash nodded. His eyes swept across his five servants and he shook his head.

“Perhaps it is time to add to your number. A new servant...perhaps. I will consider it. For now, there is much to do. Teriarch’s fury cost me a great deal of resources, not least of which is the scrolls of [Greater Teleport] that were incinerated in his fury. But that is the least of my concerns.”

He turned back to a map of the continent and his servants raised their heads, save for Ijvani and Venitra. Perril Chandler's voice was musing, thoughtful.

"Ryoka Griffin is no longer a concern, or at least, one I cannot resolve. But Zel Shivertail and the Lord of the Wall...they may be a problem. So too might the Slayer and the Small Queen. I will take steps to remedy them. Perhaps my apprentice can deal with them. That is a concern. Information about my existence may spread. If so, I will take steps. If my discovery is unavoidable..."

He fell silent. His fingers drummed rapidly on the map. And then slowed. To everyone's surprise, a smile slowly spread across Az'kerash's face.

"But there is one unexpected boon. One, among all the loss."

"What is that, master?"

Bea flinched when he turned to her. But the Necromancer just smiled.

"Why, my enemy of course. Teriarch, one of the greatest obstacles to my conquest has revealed his weakness. Another one, should I say. And it is Ryoka Griffin."

"The Runner? But—"

The undead glanced at each other, remembering the Dragon's wrathful fire and trembling at the memory. Az'kerash flicked his fingers dismissively.

"I will observe her. I will not interfere directly of course, but I will... hope that she survives."

"Why, master?"

He smiled.

"Because she is Teriarch's weakness, of course. And unlike Magnolia Reinhart, she is far less well protected. And he cares for her. Perhaps only enough to intercede. But in time, perhaps more? It matters, Bea, because Dragons have hides stronger than diamond, and hearts softer than snow."

She looked up at him, uncomprehending. He bent, caressed her rotten face and kissed her gently. She shuddered, and the other servants looked at

her with envy.

“It does not matter. Go, my servants. The time of my return is not yet. I have more to prepare. And it is a different sort of plague that falls upon the Humans and Drakes now.”

He turned his gaze back towards the map and smiled.

“Yes, a different sort. Goblins.”

The sky was bright. The sun was out. The sky was blue. Frost Faeries flew overhead, streaming north. They left, and the skies warmed. Winter had ended. So the Winter Sprites, the fae, flew one last time, laughing and calling out high overhead.

But none of the faeries looked back. None looked down at the young woman who stared up at their number. Ryoka Griffin stood in the snow and then turned. She began walking, and fumbled at her side. She pulled out an iPhone, only slightly dented from a recent fall, and two ear buds. Slowly, she put them in her ears.

There was a moment of silence as Ryoka flicked through her list of songs. In the end, she decided on *It's Time* by Imagine Dragons. She began jogging as the drums began to play.

Northwards. The gates of Celum were empty, and the sun was shining down on a muddy road. The entire world was ahead. Ryoka ran, slowly at first, and then picking up speed.

“*Ryoka!*”

Someone raced out of the gates after her. Erin Solstice ran after her friend and stopped. She cupped her hands and shouted.

“*Ryoka! Come back!*”

But it was too late. Ryoka's head turned once, and Erin saw her smile for a second. Then her head turned ahead, and she picked up her pace. Erin shouted.

A single hand rose. Ryoka lifted it, and let it fall after a moment. She ran on, northwards, away. Erin stood in the melting snow, in the frozen dirt, and watched her friend run on and on. Until she was a distant speck on the horizon. And then...

And then she was gone. Ryoka Griffin disappeared, and Erin stood in the gates of Celum. Ryoka was gone.

And as she walked back towards Octavia's shop and saw Lyonette and Mrsha hurrying through with their possessions, Erin stepped through the door to her inn. She heard shouting, saw Ishkr boarding up the windows from the outside, heard horn calls from Liscor's walls, and the drums.

The undead were gone. Few knew they'd even been here, but they were gone. Ryoka was gone. Winter had ended, and the faeries had left. Brunkr was gone. Ulrien was gone. Griffon Hunt had left.

And Ryoka was gone. She might never come back. Erin sat in her inn and heard the drum beats. There was only one thing left now, wasn't there? They had come at last. They were here, and they weren't a pest any longer. They were here. Here.

Goblins.

Author's Note:

Book 3 of The Wandering Inn was where I wrote one of my favorite new characters at the time—Geneva Scala. I don't know if you liked her, but at the time it was a 'side story' that came out of nowhere for a lot of readers.

Of course, I knew that I wanted to expand existing arcs like the King of Destruction and I had already begun introducing characters like Laken Godart. Nevertheless, I think that when Book 5 began, I got to expand what were one-note stories into more than that.

You can tell people what a character is like in a single chapter, but it takes more to make them more than a first impression. At least, that's how I see it. The Last Light was not the center of the book in terms of word-count, but that's how I remember it, in part. Of course, this features a lot of perspectives and story—and far more to come!

As I now have a habit of doing, I'm bookmarking this to where The Wandering Inn is as a web serial. It's October of 2021, and we're well into Volume 8, with hopes of finishing it this year, or early next year at the latest. You sit at Book 5, which is at the *beginning* of Volume 4. That is not to say you are halfway, since each volume gets longer. You're...about 1/3 of the story up to where the web serial is, but even so, we're releasing these e-books faster than before.

It's a lot of writing. Amazing cover art, Andrea Parsneau's excellent audio work, it all takes time! Rest assured, there are more books to come, which is good if you enjoyed this one. Hopefully so? Thanks for reading!

--pirateaba

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